VIDEHA · PARALLEL LITERARY MOVEMENT

A PARALLEL HISTORY
of Mithilā & Maithilī
Literature

PART II
TOMES V – IX

with Critical Appreciations of
Representative Maithili Writers

GAJENDRA THAKUR

Editor, Videha eJournal

Translated from original Maithili by the author himself

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A Parallel History of Mithilā & Maithilī Literature (Part 2)

with Critical Appreciations of Representative Maithili Writers

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DEDICATION

for the writers, readers, and listeners of Mithilā,

who have kept the lamp of Maithilī burning

through a thousand years of storms

“The Parallel is not the marginal,
but the truthful, in long delay.”

Mānuṣīm iha saṃskṛtām

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PART II / TOME V

Treatises, Essays and Literary Criticism

Theory and Applied Studies

Gajendra Thakur · Videha

translated from original Maithili by the author himself

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PART I — THEORY

Section A — Theoretical Treatises

Critical Methods and Theoretical Foundations

1. Treatises, Essays and Criticism: Critical Theory and the Criticism of Criticism

Abstract

Should there be a theoretical purpose for the principles of criticism, and for art and literature in Maithili? The various literary genres—poetry, treatises, essays, criticism, short fiction, the novel, epistolary writing, travel memoirs, reportage, drama and one-act plays—are heard, recited, read or performed for pleasure.

Keywords: treatise · essay · critical theory · literary criticism · Maithili

Summary · Abstract

This chapter discusses "Treatises, Essays and Criticism; Critical Theory and the Criticism of Criticism." Should there be a theoretical purpose for the principles of criticism, art and literature in Maithili? The various literary genres—poetry, treatises, essays, criticism, short fiction, the novel, epistolary literature, travel memoirs, reportage, drama and one-act plays—are heard, recited, read or performed for entertainment. They may be purposeful, or may also contain purposelessness and absurdity, for amid the upheavals of life, even purposeless literature provides entertainment. In ancient times, art, literature and music were passed from one generation to another. Padapāṭha, kramapāṭha, jaṭāpāṭha, śikhāpāṭha and ghanapāṭha were systematic methods of memorisation.

Should there be a theoretical purpose for the principles of criticism, and for art and literature in Maithili? The various literary genres—poetry,

treatises, essays, criticism, short fiction, the novel, epistolary writing, travel memoirs, reportage, drama and one-act plays—are heard, recited, read or performed for pleasure. They may be purposeful, but they may also embody purposelessness or absurdity; amid the upheavals of life, even literature without an apparent purpose affords pleasure. In ancient times, art, literature and music passed from one generation to another. Padapāṭha, kramapāṭha, jaṭāpāṭha, śikhāpāṭha and ghanapāṭha were systematic methods of memorisation. The Yajurveda described methods of building houses, altars and other artistic constructions; these were further elaborated in commentaries and became some of the earliest foundations of archaeology. The organisation of music lent the Sāmaveda its distinctive character. Attempts were thus made to give literature, art and music definite forms so that others might reproduce them in the same manner. In this process began the criticism of art, literature and music, or the analysis of their qualities.

Eastern and Western thinkers alike considered what purpose art, literature and music serve in society and what ethical standards should govern them. Plato argues that no art can be good, since it is all false and unreal. Yet art, music and literature may also be pursued for one's own delight: reading, listening, viewing and experiencing them can bring joy and peace of mind, though they may also disturb us. Aristotle, by contrast, regards artists as possessing knowledge and helping us to understand the world. Art is an aesthetically transformed representation of the world. Freud considers every human being mysterious; he selects literary works as a means of analysing the writer. Neo-Freudians, however, place greater emphasis upon cultural rather than biological factors. New Criticism is grounded in detailed attention to the work itself. Postmodernism, existentialism and humanism are all currents of philosophical thought. Philosophy formerly encompassed science, history, society and politics, economics, the sciences of art, and language. As the branches of science and the arts became increasingly specialised—science in particular—philosophy came to be confined, in its relation to mathematics and science, largely to mathematical logic. Philosophical enquiry moved towards induction and deduction and towards analytical methods.

Marx, who appeared to the poor of the world almost as a providential intervention, made the dialectical method the basis of his interpretation. Today's discussion or disputation, embracing both proposition and counter-proposition, had already existed within the Indian philosophical traditions, particularly the six systems, in the procedures of refutation and establishment exemplified by Mādhavācārya's Sarvadarśanasaṃgraha. Francis Fukuyama, who announced the end of history following the collapse of communist rule, subsequently retreated from that declaration. After the end of communism, it appeared that history, understood as a

struggle between two ideologies, had ended with the disappearance of one of them. Fukuyama declared that this was the end of history produced by ideological conflict, and that henceforth only an ideology concerned with human welfare would advance. Later, however, he acknowledged the continued existence of many divergent ideologies within societies and among nationalities. When the Berlin Wall fell, his view had been that the disappearance of communism ended the history founded on conflict, since the world had become unipolar. He now recognises that dispossessed groups exist everywhere, and that their civilisations and histories generate conflict; history, therefore, continues.

Postmodernism too has lost momentum after its initial enthusiasm. Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, Romanticism and sociological analysis have survived by entering into synthetic methods of criticism. Psychoanalysis, on account of its scientific foundations, will continue to survive, like the dialectical method. The postmodern outlook challenges the completeness of scientific knowledge. Truth and falsehood are described according to different points of view; self-centred humour accompanies a fading distinction between good and evil. Truth may at any moment become falsehood. Thought can remain superficial; there is neither optimism nor necessarily pessimism, but a kind of wilfulness in which the same thing can be conceived in several ways. Rather than trusting the outcomes of perspective, causation, control and planning, it places greater trust in chance. Democratic and feminist positions, and symbols of ideologies such as the red flag, become objects of humour and play. Postmodernism brought forward questions concerning women and many communities pushed outside the mainstream by globalisation. It opposed ideology and universal goals but could offer no answer of its own. Similarly, Jacques Derrida's deconstruction of language demonstrated that its constituent parts depend upon numerous other foundations, without understanding which we cannot establish meaning.

The analytical philosophy of positivism examines linguistic propositions and concepts rather than things themselves. Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism arose in response to science, and ambiguities in scientific thought were thereby clarified. Phenomenology studies what is given to consciousness precisely as it is given. Experience is the observation of the facts of a particular mental act; it offers a means of viewing an object independently and in its pure form. In existentialism, the human being is nothing other than the human being: one is not separate from what one creates. Sartre says that humanity is condemned to be free. Hegel's dialectic places emphasis on judging the qualities and existence of a process through the endless interplay of analysis and synthesis. The deeper the underlying principle, the further it lies from outward form and the closer it is to reality.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also influenced modern thinking. Beneath visible reality, internal and external processes are made possible through the exchange of minute elements of force and energy. According to the principle of uncertainty, position and form must be determined by approximation. The conception of a universe with more than three dimensions and Stephen Hawking's A Brief History of Time directly challenge the existence of God; with them, even the concept of God's death comes into view. Whatever has begun will end, however long its life may be. Just as virtual reality artificially presents reality and makes consciousness identify with it, without imagining more than three dimensions we would not have reached the far side of the universe even if we had travelled at the speed of light since the Indus Valley civilisation. These scientific and philosophical propositions confront literature as challenges. A holistic or comprehensive synthesis is needed: only then can philosophy pass from the merely philosophical into the real.

Poststructuralist methodology locates linguistic meaning not in words, their fixed meanings or grammatical rules, but in the process through which meaning is produced. That meaning differs among persons and groups of every kind. There is no final relationship between language and the world, no final or uniquely determinate meaning of a word or its text. Modern and postmodern arguments concerning reality, dialogue and the exchange of ideas shaped the emergence of modernity. New Left movements arose in France, alongside tendencies such as nihilism and anarchism. These movements rested on distrust that had moved beyond modern modes of thought and their established beliefs and concepts. Concealed meanings in texts began to be interpreted in their temporal and spatial contexts, while language was treated as a game—a language-game. Postmodernism arose as a critique of power, legitimacy and their stratification.

In the computer and information revolution, a programmer creates software and places it on the World Wide Web, where the software continues to function independently of its maker, at times even performing tasks for which it was never designed. Intrusive software, such as a virus, can divert it from its course and make it destructive; an antivirus is itself software that attempts to repair the damage. When even this fails, the computer is backed up and formatted: a clean slate. Capitalism arose with the Industrial Revolution. In post-industrial society, information and communication have gained importance over production, and computers play an expanding social role. Mobile phones, credit cards and comparable devices are based on chips. Ideas of deconstruction and reconstruction point towards the restructuring of creative processes and the new ways in which consciousness is formed in the post-industrial age. It is not history itself, but traditional history, that has ended. State, class,

nation, political party, society, family, morality and marriage are all being redefined. Rapid change has fragmented many institutions and deprived them of their former contexts.

An information society is one in which the creation, distribution, dissemination, use, integration and modification of information constitute important economic, political and cultural activities. Those able to participate in such a society are called digital citizens. In this post-industrial order, information technology shapes production, the economy and society. The concept is close to those of postmodern and post-industrial society. The economist Fritz Machlup introduced the concept. His idea of the knowledge industry rested on five areas: education, research and development, the media, information technology and information services. It thus reveals the social effects of technology and information. The digital divide is at once a division of knowledge, society and economic resources. It shows the need for a non-discriminatory information society in which developing countries enjoy sovereign rights over information technology. Human rights in relation to information technology include the individual's right to privacy. Scholars, human-rights activists and others have begun debating whether a society founded upon information and communication technology will strengthen or damage human rights, particularly freedom of expression, the right to information, privacy, non-discrimination, women's equality, intellectual property, political participation and freedom of association.

The confidentiality of online correspondence, cultural and linguistic diversity in internet content, media education and the technical instruments of the information society are bound up with rights and freedoms, and with society's overall development. They bear upon the universality of rights and freedoms, the differences among rights, and participation in the determination of liberty and values. They make information, knowledge and culture easier to access, turning the user into an actor within the global information society. Users thereby acquire greater freedom of expression and the ability to create new content and new social networks. This also gives rise to a need for new legal, economic and social models founded upon shared responsibility, knowledge and cooperation. The interests of children are another concern and should always take precedence over those of adults.

The modern tendency to accumulate economic, social and cultural wealth has intensified in the information society, while technology has brought a form of structural unemployment. Poverty, workers' rights and the idea of the welfare state are being pushed aside by calculations of profit and loss. Only a handful of leading actors are now wanted. Publishers, too, promote only a few authors whose books sell particularly well; the same tendency is

visible in theatre, painting, cinema and other fields. Information, however, is not always beneficial. It encompasses not only art and books but also the stock market and sponsored survey reports. It reduces the distance between time and space and establishes a balance between them. The principle of human dignity shifts emphasis away from status assigned at birth towards the universal right to dignity. Movements for liberation and women's liberation have worked in this direction. After the two world wars and the challenge of fascism, the United Nations General Assembly proclaimed and adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights on 10 December 1948. It established a common standard for all peoples and nations, without discrimination on political, economic, cultural or religious grounds.

Yet the free use of information is limited, and people's privacy is disappearing. During a visit to India, Bill Gates was asked whether Microsoft had delayed introducing its Xbox in India for fear of piracy; he replied that Microsoft had never delayed a product for that reason. The fear of spam and piracy ought to end. The information society is the society in which we live today. Respect for democracy and human rights must continue in the information society and in the society that follows it. Freedom of expression, the right to privacy, the right to share information and the right of access to it—all of which concern the communication of information—remain threatened by the state and by the market-oriented tendencies of the information society.

The internet is a medium belonging to the people, a system through which individuals communicate with one another. It breaks down the strongholds of those who have dominated the communications media. In general, the internet has no editor. People themselves create subjects and content and disseminate what they produce. This initiates many social conversations, but it also gives circulation to antisocial material. Should such material therefore be prohibited? If software is allowed to empower a machine to impose restrictions on content, freedom of expression will suffer a serious blow.

In India, intellectual-property law grants an author's heirs the right to publish and distribute the work for sixty years after the author's death. Piracy must be restrained on the internet as well, and arrangements must ensure that the author's rights over the material remain effective in practice, not merely in principle, throughout those sixty years. Excessive reliance on patents, however, will obstruct developing countries' access to information and impede technological development. Copyright can also foster cultural development, as in the growth of music, film, comics and illustrated narratives. In a digital environment, one cannot even view material online without making a copy; accordingly, online and offline

copyright are not entirely the same. Online copyright also restricts reproduction, although it is extremely easy to incorporate copied material into something else or to modify it. Names and images should not be used without their creators' permission. No one should intrude upon another person's private conversations or chats, nor make statements that create false impressions of another person.

Likewise, when employers install electronic devices to monitor their employees, their conduct should accord with the guidelines of the International Labour Organization. Unsolicited email messages and the unauthorised collection or use of medical reports also constitute violations of human rights. Internet use nevertheless remains restricted because much content and software is expensive rather than freely available. The digital divide makes differences in educational attainment more conspicuous. Since information work involves more mental than physical labour, there was a hope that gender inequality might diminish in the information society. Surveys, however, show that women's participation in information technology remains limited. Electronic libraries, Braille-enabled and audio-enabled computer screens, and comparable facilities may allow disabled and blind people to engage in e-commerce from home; yet the cost of research and its results has prevented these technologies from delivering their full benefits. Children, older people, disabled people, women, workers, migrant workers and other socially disadvantaged groups continue to experience disadvantage in the information society. As their access to information technology increases, inequality within that society can diminish.

Good literature and art do not come into being through the mere immediacy of presentation. Their foundation lies in sharply articulated human values, elements of social harmony, and principles of social belief grounded in equality and justice. We must ask whether a work conveys with sufficient force a vision of how society might advance upon those foundations. Does it free the reader's mind from its constraints? Does it encourage self-confidence and the capacity to lead others? Does it remove doubts about the formation of character and about respect for labour? Such questions should become standards by which short fiction is judged. Those who live on society's margins may accomplish things beyond the abilities of the privileged; this can become possible when the self-confidence of the marginalised grows.

How can literature burdened by a sense of inferiority promote human welfare? Within changing social, economic, political and religious relationships, the one-sidedness of representation and the uncertainties of a poet's or storyteller's personal commitments—whether to ideology, caste or religion—inevitably become visible in the writing. We must identify

the sense of superiority, itself another form of inferiority, that appears in stories about favours bestowed by oppressors upon the oppressed or written out of the oppressor's guilt.

Mediocrity must be recognised. Stock phrases and the fleeting currency of breaking news, offered in the name of modernity, cannot provide ideas capable of engaging with the propositions of an age. Modernisation, democratisation, the implementation of the nation-state, administrative and legal development, greater public participation, stability, the capacity for orderly change, the dynamics of power and industrialisation all intersect. After independence, the processes of transformation and integration through which new states confront their political, social, economic and cultural problems may sometimes be mutually contradictory. Attention must also be paid to the development of community and to psychological and educational processes.

Indigenous communities such as the Satar and Gidarmara (Banjara) reflect diversity, closeness to nature, nature worship, simplicity, innocence, gratitude and differing levels of development. An individual's standing often depends on locality and caste. Certain castes possess prestige and privilege, whereas others are despised and endure difficult lives.

The Rigveda refers to twenty-one women seers: Apala, Ghosha, Shraddha, Shachi, Sarparajni, Yami, Vaivasvati, Devajamaya, Indrani, Shashvati, Romasha, Godha, Urvashi, Surya, Aditi, Nadi, Lopamudra, Vishvavara, Vak-Juhu, Sarama and Yami. To secure women's rights in the fields of women and child development, the education system must be mobilised and women's studies given a prominent place in the curriculum. The proportion of women in vocational and technical education should increase. Feminism and the women's movement have made an impact in this direction. Secular political institutions, grounded in the economic and social interests of entire communities, can promote social values free from discrimination based on religion, race or creed. If educational development precedes economic development, ordinary people will be able to participate in it. Such participation increases creative capacity and the sense of responsibility.

Science and technology have heightened the need to reconcile the gap between developed and less developed, or developing, nations with the aspiration to solve human problems—disease, ignorance and insecurity—and with the apparently unlimited expansion of hopes, possibilities and material facilities. The legal system should be used to secure justice for poor and disadvantaged groups. Civil liberty, democratic rights, freedom of thought, the creation of a capable society and freedom from constraint and oppression are fundamental values. Together with these, the press—as a link between rulers and ruled—plays a significant role in social,

economic and political life. Powerful advertising agencies, however, are increasingly proving capable of shaping public opinion.

The creation of new institutions and the reform of existing ones, resistance to feudal, tribal, caste and sectarian loyalties, and the practices of democracy, liberalism, republicanism, constitutionalism, socialism and egalitarianism all remain important. Constitutional rights, regularly scheduled popular elections, popular sovereignty, the federal division of powers, the significance of public opinion, public-administrative processes and initiatives, the formation of party-interest groups, a supreme legislature, an accountable executive and an independent judiciary continue to perform their respective roles. Meanwhile, pollution and ecological imbalance are being produced by harmful changes to the physical, chemical and biological qualities of water, land and air.

Michel Foucault argues that knowledge and truth are constructed. Deleuze and Guattari contend that we desire because we are desiring-machines. Mikhail Bakhtin regards language as a social act, and his work concentrates on the novel. The Russian Formalists treat literature as a distinctive use of language. According to Jean-François Lyotard, truth and the truth of history are merely apparent. Baudrillard maintains that advertising and television have erased the distinction between reality and appearance. Both are leading thinkers of postmodernism.

Lacan's distinctive contribution is the linguistic application of Freud's method. He holds that the unconscious is structured like a language. When a child learns language, a word is taught in relation to a sign. Lacan elaborates three elements: desire, lack and the Other. Desire contains both need and demand, yet cannot be divided into these two alone. The description of the Other introduces lack and emptiness. The subject is a momentary effect of meaning, and it becomes like the Other when it is imaginary and gives rise to lack, from which desire emerges.

Three major thinkers of postcolonialism are Homi Bhabha, associated with Foucault and Lacan; Gayatri Spivak, associated with Foucault and Derrida; and Edward Said, associated with Foucault. They interpret the practices and theoretical constructions through which colonialism attributed qualities such as cunning and indolence to colonised peoples.

Raymond Williams's cultural studies demonstrate the relationship between literature and economic conditions. New Historicism compares the textuality of history with the historicity of texts. Elaine Showalter identifies psychological, biological and linguistic characteristics of women's writing. Simone de Beauvoir regards class and caste as obstacles to women's commitment to women, a position challenged by later feminist theory. Virginia Woolf considers economic independence and privacy

essential to women writers, although her views have not been regarded as revolutionary. Mary Wollstonecraft advocated a revolution in women's education, with an emphasis on education in reason.

Within New Criticism, T. S. Eliot opposed the predominance of emotion in poetry and insisted upon impersonality. One responsibility of the critic is to refine public taste. Wimsatt and Beardsley argued that criticism should rest neither on the poet's intentions nor on historical study. Nor should it depend upon emotional effects on readers, since these are relative; it should be grounded in the actual verbal substance of the work. The beginnings of English criticism may be traced to Philip Sidney, who considered poetry in relation to beauty, meaning and human welfare. John Dryden reflected on moral instruction in ancient literature and its advantages and disadvantages. Samuel Johnson wrote about the comic and tragic elements in Shakespeare's plays.

Rousseau's Romanticism does not doubt the fundamental goodness of human beings, whereas classical critics are sceptical and neoclassical critics hold that human nature is corrupt but institutions can improve it. Romanticism nevertheless argues that institutions themselves are corrupt and only help corrupt people. It understands poetry as personal experience. Structuralism attacked modern positionalism, which did not question literature's position, and subsequently deprived the author of the exclusive authority to interpret the text he or she had written. Poststructuralism asserted that literature exceeds the limits within which structuralism understands it. Postmodernism is one form of poststructuralism. Poststructuralist thought also proposes that literary structures work within culture and theory in ways that exclude certain emotions and ideas resistant to continuity. Deconstruction and postmodernism emerged after poststructuralism.

Postcolonialism rejects new forms of colonialism; theories of disorder, similarly, understand failed intentions in terms of the failure to attain appropriate outcomes. Structuralism strikes at oppressive Western social arrangements and structures, and thereby gave added strength to Marxism, as in Althusser. After modernist positionalism, New Criticism, structuralism and poststructuralism came deconstruction and postmodernism, the latter also described as late capitalism by Fredric Jameson. In the eighteenth century, 'modern' signified rootlessness; at the beginning of the twentieth century, it came to suggest progressivism. After 1970, modernity assumed the form of a theory, and 'postmodern' became a technical term within which the worldly lost its former importance. Life and history up to the modern age were rendered insignificant, as though they had ended. This became a theory of the posthistorical, the

postdevelopmental and the postcausal. Truth and interconnection ceased to command importance.

Magical realism inserts magical elements into real situations. Gabriel García Márquez's One Hundred Years of Solitude and Salman Rushdie's Midnight's Children are examples of such novels. Writers employ this technique to attempt a fuller understanding of reality. Joseph Conrad calls the novel history. Conrad, a Polish speaker who became a celebrated English novelist, did not speak English fluently. Roland Barthes declares that the novel is both history and a challenge to history. Barthes was a French literary theorist whose writing influenced structuralist, Marxist and poststructuralist theories of literature.

Using the visual and audiovisual media of the Western bourgeoisie, postmodernists treat inequality, injustice and dispossession as though they were merely words set against equality, attainment and justice. Poverty, which is not a major problem in the West, remains a serious problem in India today. Postmodernism stands in opposition to feminism and Marxism, and both have opposed it. Marxism supports historical analysis and has thereby renewed the strength of its own theory in relation to structuralism, poststructuralism and postmodernism. Marxism emphasises material life, but that does not make it identical with utilitarianism or the Cārvāka school, for these attend only to bodily needs. Feminist thought also opposes postmodernism's defence of the status quo: until that is overcome, the position of women cannot improve.

A devatā means the subject being expounded, not 'God', as Griffith suggests. Maharshi Patañjali's scientific statement concerning the interpretation of mantras—'yac chabda āha tad asmākaṃ pramāṇam', that which the word or phrase of the mantra says is our authority—later came to be understood, incorrectly, as meaning that the Veda alone is authoritative. Plato maintains that no art can be good because all art is false and unreal. Yet Plato's position should also be read in the context of Athens' military organisation being inferior to that of Sparta. His opposition to poetry and drama arose from the belief that memorising and repeating dialogue would draw people towards an artificial life. Aristotle does not regard poetry merely as imitation; he perceives in it philosophy and universal truth. He considers tragedy and imitation in drama to bring a release following pleasure, compassion and fear. Dialogue can take two forms, formal address and conversation, the latter containing fewer philosophical elements.

In ancient Greece, poetry was understood as a message from the divine. Aristophanes distinguishes good and bad poetry; Theophrastus distinguishes severe, excellent and grand poetry. Poetry and music are inseparable. European symphonic music, however, in which many

instruments perform together in differing rhythms, brought a change in the theory. Related questions also applied to the dramatic stage. Derrida's method of deconstruction brings highly placed works and authors down and raises those placed below them. Roland Barthes writes that a work becomes significant when it separates from its maker and can be analysed independently, a process he calls the death of the author. Poststructuralism overturned structuralism's conception of a complete and well-ordered system. Saussure's theory of language—speech and writing, the language of a particular period and its historical context, the question of whether the significant entity is a work or a person, and whether significance is itself a conception—was also subjected to reversal and interrogation by Derrida's deconstruction.

Sex is a biological fact, whereas the conceptual distinctions between woman and man are social outcomes. Literature and art concerning women have been produced by men and have regarded women through a male gaze. Feminist literary theory enters into the depths of this problem. In Mithila, women's position is not uniformly so poor, yet the one-sided tendency of Maithili literature has represented the difficulties of upper-class women. Modernisation has also brought a deterioration in women's position among so-called lower castes. Furthermore, caste and religion have divided women's rights into compartments. Feminist criticism likewise argues that theories constructed by men cannot offer a complete explanation.

Liberal humanism arose in opposition to theoretical systems. It argues that, rather than submitting literature to theory, one can use ordinary judgement to determine whether a work possesses a humane vision and genuine significance. By exercising one's own intelligence, one can judge literary quality without the necessity of a formal literary theory. Yet liberal humanism itself became a theory, within which meaningful literature was produced.

A book review should avoid excessive denunciation. The critic should resist the urge to display his or her erudition: excessive criticism often turns into an exhibition of the reviewer's learning. Restraint is essential, and abusive vocabulary reveals the critic's poor upbringing. Reviewing a book without reading it is unethical. For example, writing about Dhumketu in Karmadhāraya, Taranand Viyogi states: 'His story “Namāze Śukrānā” is very important in highlighting the communal harmony established over the ages in Mithila's culture' (Karmadhāraya, p. 127). The judgement appears to have been made from the title alone. In the story, when Haji Saheb is at prayer, a parrot in a cage cries, 'Sita ... Ram ...'. Haji Saheb repeatedly strikes the parrot's cage against the mosque wall until the bird

dies. Saeeda begins to weep, and the story ends. Yet, in the critic's view, this tale illustrates communal harmony!

Indian conceptions of poetry begin with the idea of art as a path to liberation, or mokṣa. Consider the posture of Nataraja, in which the rhythm of creation and destruction can be seen together. A permanent emotional disposition, deepening and ripening, becomes rasa. How many such rasas were experienced by Sita and Rama? The Valmiki Ramayana offers examples. Krishna teaches the Indian doctrine of action, yet he is also a connoisseur of aesthetic relish. The need to understand the experience of art gave rise to rasa theory, and Bharata composed the Nāṭyaśāstra. Abhinavagupta wrote a commentary on Anandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka. Bhāmaha in the sixth century, Daṇḍin in the seventh and Rudraṭa in the ninth further advanced these discussions.

Rasa theory. For Bharata, rasa arises through the effect of drama. Why does drama exist? It exists both to enact rasa and to bring rasa into being. How does rasa emerge? Through its determinants or causes (vibhāva), its consequent expressions (anubhāva), and associated transitory states (vyabhicāribhāva). The enduring emotional disposition becomes concentrated and ripens into rasa, which can be savoured. For Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa, the permanent emotion intensifies through causes and effects until it becomes rasa. Actors experience rasa through investigation and imagination. Lollaṭa gives no comparable importance to the poet or to the listener and spectator. Śaunaka holds that the spectator must enter imaginatively into a performance to experience rasa, as one apprehends a painted horse as though it were a horse. Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka argues that rasa acts upon the spectator and that the language of the poet is distinctive. Through rasa, the soul of the listener or spectator meets the supreme soul. Its pleasure is ananda in its essential form, leading to self-realisation. Rasa theory is thus founded upon, and gives emphasis to, listeners, spectators and readers.

Dhvani theory. In the Dhvanyāloka, Anandavardhana argues that literature aims to suggest meaning indirectly or to bring meaning into being. The theory explains the structure and function of suggested meaning, rasa as aesthetic experience, and the place of figures of speech. For Anandavardhana, dhvani, or suggestion, is the soul of poetry. Although meaning emerges indirectly through suggestion, it does so in an organised form. The resulting theory concerns both meaning and symbol, and through them the experience and production of rasa. Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā opposed the theory, contending that dhvani has no independent existence: it is an effect of inference, already covered by secondary signification. Not everything, moreover, can be conveyed through words.

Sphoṭa theory. Bhartṛhari's Vākyapadīya holds that the meaning of words and sentences is conveyed through sphoṭa. Varṇa-sphoṭa pertains to phonemes, pada-sphoṭa to words and vākya-sphoṭa to sentences. Knowledge is impossible without a relationship to language. This became part of the Indian philosophical theory of knowledge. Meaning can be communicated without the simultaneous material presence of letters, words and sentences. Sphoṭa is śabda-brahman, the word-principle considered the fundamental cause of creation. Letters, words and sentences do not exist together at a single instant. The individual sounds of an uttered word do not, separately, contain the meaning of the word; they arise and pass away until the word is complete. Sphoṭa nevertheless communicates meaning even though the letters, words or sentences do not remain physically present throughout the act of reception or transmission. Each successive letter contributes to meaningfulness as the word reaches completion, just as successive words contribute to the completion of the sentence. Sāṃkhya, Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta reject sphoṭa, maintaining instead that letters and their sounds adequately constitute meaning. Jacques Derrida's French theories of deconstruction and dissemination have affinities with sphoṭa theory.

Alaṅkāra theory. Bhāmaha treats figures of speech in terms of samāsokti, a form that becomes a source of aesthetic pleasure. Daṇḍin and Udbhaṭa likewise developed the theory of ornament. Figures of speech are fundamentally of two kinds, based respectively upon sound and meaning; further classifications concern resemblance and contrast, logical and popular modes of reasoning, poetic conventions and the apprehension of hidden meanings. Mammaṭa divides sixty-one figures into seven groups: simile (upamā), metaphor (rūpaka), indirect praise (aprastuta), the illuminating or distributing figure (dīpaka), contrast (vyatireka), contradiction (virodha) and combination (samuccaya).

Aucitya theory. In the Aucityavicāracarcā, Kṣemendra regards propriety or appropriateness as a fundamental principle of literature. Where should appropriateness be observed? In individual words; sentences; the meaning of a composition; qualities; figures of speech; rasa; grammatical cases; verbs; gender; number; adjectives; prefixes; particles; time; place; lineage; observances; principles; inward qualities; intention; temperament; the selection of essential material; creative genius; circumstance; thought; names; and benedictions. The universe vibrates; it is nothing but vibration. After poetry is recited, stillness spreads—peace everywhere, peace spreading through the mind.

Translation criticism. Among the forms of creative literature, drama is the most difficult to translate, followed by poetry and then fiction. A translator of drama must recognise the dramatic background and indirect

implications, while also understanding the psychology of the characters. Translating poetry demands familiarity with its genre and construction. When translating a Maithili haiku into English, for example, matching Maithili's five-seven-five pattern of letters to the English alphabet would make the translation absurd: English haiku use five-seven-five syllables, and a letter does not correspond to a syllable in English as it may in Maithili. One must attend to poetic rhythm and imagery, and relate individual sections to the poem's main body. In narrative fiction, the translator needs to understand the narrator, the characters, the sequence of events, the time and period of flashbacks, and the setting. Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili Ramcharitmanas is a translation from Awadhi into Maithili, but its dohas, chaupais and sorathas have been translated in their traditional metrical forms. Why, then, is theory necessary?

2. Pattern Poetry and Shape Poetry in Maithili

Abstract

In Maithili, for the first time: (1) pattern or repetition poetry and (2) shape or concrete poetry. Poetry written according to the metre of lines is pattern poetry. It is a verse composition in which something recurs repeatedly. The repetition need not be of sound; only the lengths of the lines are repeated.

Keywords: Maithili · pattern · poetry · shape · repetition · going · someone

In Maithili, for the first time: (1) pattern or repetition poetry and (2) shape or concrete poetry.

1

Pattern (Repetition) Poetry

Poetry composed in the metre of lines is pattern, or repetition, poetry.

What is the metre of lines?

It is a composition in verse in which some element recurs again and again. A repetition of sounds is not required; what recurs is only the length of the lines.

Example:

> Going, Going
> Going, going, I go as far as a very distant country from which I cannot return.
> Several times before, I have returned to this place.
> I understood that the road was only halfway traversed.
> When I did return,
> I set out again, bound for the distant place,
> for a country so distant that I could not return.
> Anyone setting out to return would tire before reaching even half of that halfway road,
> and, should they press ahead, would see the road disappearing.
> I shall leave no path behind, nor

any sign by which to know it,
nor surrender even a little hope.
The road beyond halfway, crossing and breaking through,
and I, advancing, and the vanishing road, brought the task to its conclusion.
Now another task will begin again,
with a new environment and new people.
Experiment upon experiment
will bring some extraordinary outcome,
or push me once more towards a faraway country.
And shall I not return again to my former country,
where those frightened people of old will no longer be,
nor the old familiar trees and plants?
Evidence upon evidence of an outcome
seems to have turned away from me.
The people, trees and plants of this country are all new,
with no familiar sign, no hope, and no recognisable road.

2.

Shape or Concrete Poetry

Unlike pattern or repetition poetry, shape poetry assumes a visible form. Thus, instead of the recurring line-lengths found in pattern poetry, one sees a figure. Consider, for example, the figure of a tree below.

A familiar sign of vanishing hope
I see
trees on either side,
travelling with the road,
the shade of trees growing dense.
My familiar sign will surely become denser, but

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darkness becomes impenetrably thick.
The familiar sign of my hope disappears.

3. A Navya-Nyāya Perspective: Valid Cognition, Absence and Epistemic Validity

Abstract

This collection contains numerous propositions concerning knowledge, embodied in dramatic form, which can be examined using the conceptual resources of Navya-Nyāya. In Forty Thieves, every victory of Gonu is a victory of inference and reasoning—in other words, of valid cognition (pramā). In the confrontation between force and intelligence, the play places the operation of evidence above everything else. A line from Sukanya—'When you close your eyes, you will not see the tree, yet everything remains present'—brings a central insight of Navya-Nyāya onto the stage: the absence of knowledge of an object does not mean that the object itself is absent (non-apprehension is not absence).

Keywords: Navya-Nyāya; pramā; inference; absence; non-apprehension; epistemic validity; folk knowledge.

This collection contains numerous propositions concerning knowledge, embodied in dramatic form, which can be examined using the conceptual resources of Navya-Nyāya. In Forty Thieves, every victory of Gonu is a victory of inference and reasoning—in other words, of valid cognition (pramā). In the confrontation between force and intelligence, the play places the operation of evidence above everything else.

The line from Sukanya—'When you close your eyes, you will not see the tree, yet everything remains present'—brings a central insight of Navya-Nyāya onto the stage: the absence of knowledge of an object does not mean the absence of the object itself (non-apprehension is not absence). When there is no contact between an object and the senses, perception does not occur, but the object continues to exist. This distinction between cognition and what is cognised becomes, in the play, an ethical argument for acknowledging reality.

The argument about 'meaningfulness' in Shruvavati and the 'discrimination between milk and water' in Atiratha both raise questions about relations and the knowledge of attributes: which quality, within which relationship, is meaningful or worthy of acceptance? In this sense, Kunal's plays, beneath the appearance of entertainment, also convey an indigenous epistemology.

At a broader level, the collection as a whole raises the question of epistemic validity: the authenticity of folk knowledge and collective memory. The Salhes ballads, the Gonu cycle and the Bidapat dance are not 'unauthentic' folk narratives; they are evidence of a parallel tradition of knowledge. That is the collection's unspoken affirmation.

Genre-Specific Critical Theory

4. The Place of the Vihani Tale in Prose Literature and Its Critical Theory

Abstract

Among the many forms of prose—treatises, essays, criticism, short fiction, novels, epistolary literature, travel memoirs and reportage—stories, narratives and novels draw particularly upon imagination blended with experience. All are close to what we call khissa-pihani, the telling of tales. Stories, narratives and novels, and to a certain extent plays and one-act plays, are heard, told, read or performed for entertainment.

Keywords: vihani · tale · story · is · also · but · critical theory

I

Among the various prose genres—treatises, essays, criticism, short fiction, novels, epistolary literature, travel memoirs and reportage—stories, narratives and novels are especially grounded in imagination interwoven with experience. They are close to what we call *khissa-pihani*, the telling of tales. Stories, narratives and novels, and to some extent plays and one-act plays, are listened to, narrated, read or performed for entertainment. They may have a definite purpose, or they may also contain purposelessness—absurdity. Amid the bustle of life, even purposeless literature provides pleasure.

When we say *vihani katha*, we identify a genre that is a tale first and a *vihani* tale second. In English, too, works are classified by length as short stories, novelettes, novellas and novels. Across Maithili genres, word counts fluctuate more widely than in English or other European languages, although in those languages as well the length of a work varies with an author's personal preference and the demands of the subject. Likewise, the one-act play is an *ekanki*, while a play is a *natak*.

A *vihani katha*, then, is certainly a tale.

Your imagination, enriched by experience, urges you to say something. The material may become a humorous anecdote or a non-humorous vignette. People may tell you that you have a great gift for spinning stories and that you are quick-witted. Encouraged, you begin shaping the material in the mould of literary craft, until it becomes a *vihani* tale.

The greatest obstacle with a humorous anecdote is that the one you tell may travel from person to person and return to you; its originality may be lost somewhere along the way. Such anecdotes may run from a line or two to half a page or an entire page. They can be incorporated into a story or

novel, but the *vihani* tale does not afford that sort of room. Nevertheless, as in a story or novel, where an anecdote becomes meaningful when placed in a character's mouth or connected with another incident, you may do the same in a *vihani* tale. Fiction emerges from narrative, and moral instruction, inspirational stories and mystical tales range from shorter to longer forms. It would also be wrong to say that none of their shorter forms can be a *vihani* tale.

The immediate presentation of an idea, so often found in the *vihani* tale, is also present in stories and novels. Yet it is not true that a work ceases to be a *vihani* tale merely because it lacks this immediacy. Quite the contrary: when reviewing a *vihani* tale, the critic ought to attend to its enduring elements rather than merely to the speed of its presentation. An excessive preference for the instantly delivered idea turns it into a non-humorous vignette. It may remain a *vihani* tale, but it will not be an outstanding one. Nor is it correct to argue that only a tale which gives the reader a sudden jolt qualifies as a *vihani* tale—or as an excellent one—and that one which fails to do so is not a *vihani* tale at all. An idea comes suddenly, and you jot it down lest it be forgotten: that much is fine. But before hastily turning it into a *vihani* tale, allow the idea to mature. Consider what might be blended into it to give it lasting substance. You might write a startling *vihani* tale without letting the idea mature, but the chance that it will also be an outstanding one is small. Just as there is no guarantee that a catchy song will retain its force for long, we must ask whether this form of storytelling might become the literary equivalent of Twenty20 cricket.

A novel cannot be read in a single sitting, whereas a short story can, and a *vihani* tale can likewise be read at one sitting. The novel permits the author a fullness of description—of setting, plot and characters—that is impossible in a short story. The latter concentrates on one aspect, or, one might say, one incident; in doing so it can offer only a broad descriptive sketch of the setting and of a person's life. The *vihani* tale allows no room even for such a rough sketch. It too centres on one aspect or one incident, but that aspect or incident should have such an independent attraction that the writer is tempted to present it in its own right rather than extinguish its independence by absorbing it into a short story or novel.

Thus the plot of a story will be simpler than that of a novel, while a *vihani* tale does not even require such a plot. Fashion an aspect or an incident within the mould of literary craft, and a complete *vihani* tale is ready.

A Critical Theory of the Vihani Tale

How should one review a *vihani* tale? An imaginative narrative shaped by experience, ranging from two lines to a page and a half or two pages (sometimes even five), is entitled to be called a *vihani* tale. If an entire

story is narrated in full within a short space, it will no longer be called a *vihani* tale. But if a sequence of incidents is needed to convey a particular proposition, the sequence must be complete; its links may be somewhat longer. Hurrying to achieve an immediate effect can weaken those links. Always reversing the current and manufacturing a sudden effect has become a formula for some well-regarded writers of *vihani* tales. In one or two pieces it may be as attractive as an 'item song' in a film; thereafter the critic begins to notice the formula, because what was proactive becomes reactive. It cannot produce a lasting effect and suggests a want of creative ability. The finest *vihani* tale constructs a sequence of events and leaves readers to reach their own verdict. The form offers little space for explanation, but that does not mean everything should be said in two or four lines. If a writer calls a two- or four-line piece a *vihani* tale, the critic is obliged to recognise the designation; the likelihood of its being an outstanding *vihani* tale, however, diminishes.

The subject of a *vihani* tale is not confined to an incident glimpsed in passing. Its writers should also create tales for children and on moral and religious themes. At present, experiences gathered while travelling by train or bus, or while sitting at home or talking beside the fire on the veranda, are often all that enter the form. Social and economic questions can provide it with lasting subject matter, as can political issues and natural disasters. While reviewing it, critics should not produce what might be called a Puranic review: in the Shiva Purana, Shiva is supreme; in the Garuda Purana, Garuda is supreme. Criticism must not degenerate into the declaration that whatever happens to be presented is a *vihani* tale, however it may be written. The novelist has ample room to demonstrate the full range of creative ability; the short-story writer has less, and the *vihani* writer still less. Yet a broader range of subjects can meet the reader's expectations. By limiting dialogue, or placing it before the main presentation, the writer can strengthen the tale; otherwise it may turn into a one-act play or drama. A *vihani* tale may be absorbed into a story or novel, but for it to attain distinction as a *vihani* tale, humorous anecdotes should not be forced into it. Space is already limited. If dialogue and an anecdote are both crammed in, the effect will not last and the work may turn into a stunted *vihani* tale.

The standard of a good *vihani* tale is not the immediacy of its delivery, but the acuity with which it presents human values, social harmony, and social principles grounded in equality and justice. We must ask whether it communicates sharply how society might move forward on that basis; whether readers are released from mental bondage; whether they acquire the capacity to lead others and gain confidence in themselves; whether their doubts about moral development and respect for labour are resolved. All these are criteria of the *vihani* tale. Marginalised people may

accomplish what those with privileges cannot; this will be possible only when the self-confidence of the marginalised grows. How can literature saturated with an inferiority complex contribute to human welfare? Against changing social, economic, political and religious relationships, the one-sidedness of a presentation, and the writer's personal lack of firmness—whether in ideology or in attitudes towards caste and religion —become visible in literature. We must identify the sense of superiority, itself a form of inferiority, which emerges in accounts of benefactions bestowed by an oppressor upon the oppressed or written from a feeling of guilt. Identify mediocrity. Stock phrases and passing 'breaking news' must not be passed off as modernity.

The *vihani* tale describes one aspect or incident, and it need not be confined to a single page. You might describe an incident in three or four pages and it would still be a *vihani* tale. Every story in James Joyce's *Dubliners* presents, through an incident, an unexpected moment of sudden understanding. Joyce's fifteen short stories occupy some two hundred pages, yet possess the defining features of Maithili *vihani* tales; above all, the element called 'epiphany' establishes their affinity with the form. Many longer short stories by Kahlil Gibran and Anton Chekhov may likewise be considered *vihani* tales. In English and European literatures, 'short story' and 'story' are sometimes used synonymously. The novel—*upanyas* in Bengali and Maithili, *kadambari* in Marathi—has a wider reach. In Maithili a work of fifty or sixty pages can already be called a novel, although in English that length falls around the upper reaches of the short story, novelette or novella. Maithili practice differs from English practice: a children's tale may continue over many nights, while a tale for adults may finish in a few minutes. In Maithili, the currently recognised limits appear to be one page for a *vihani* tale, three or four pages for a short story, fifteen to twenty pages for a long story, and sixty to five hundred pages for a novel. In my view, the *vihani* tale's permissible span needs to be extended to one to four pages.

Some of Maithili's Finest Vihani Tales

There has been a considerable qualitative change in the subject matter and vocabulary of Maithili *vihani* tales.

Durganand Mandal's 'Kisna Mutthi' demonstrates the need for an authentic vocabulary in the *vihani* tale. Just as R. K. Narayan handles English vocabulary with consummate skill, Durganand Mandal makes skilful use of Maithili words. Rampravesh Mandal similarly makes even an ordinary *vihani* tale extraordinary through his choice of words. Rajdev Mandal writes poetry, novels and *vihani* tales with equal, and consistently high, accomplishment. His reputation for balancing subject and form is well deserved. Bechan Thakur can write a *vihani* tale about the social

utility of superstition ('Phusik Phal'). Umesh Mandal's 'Rupaiya ke Dheri' is among Maithili's finest *vihani* tales on women's empowerment. The *vihani* tales of Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Parmeshwar Kapari, Kaushal Kumar, Bhavnath Jha, Shambhu Kumar Singh, Jagadanand Jha 'Manu', Lakshmi Das and Ramlochan Thakur show the Joycean epiphany with a clarity seldom found in other Maithili practitioners. Ashish Anchinhar, Amit Mishra and Chandan Kumar Jha attest to the newer generation's changing subjects and experiments. Om Prakash Jha's 'Special Permit' and Mihir Jha's '100 Taka' will have a special place in the history of Maithili *vihani* tales because of the freshness and distinctiveness of their subjects. Sandeep Kumar Safi's 'Andhvishwas' takes a position opposite to Bechan Thakur's 'Phusik Phal'; the two demonstrate how writers may give their *vihani* tales a purpose while taking opposing positions for and against superstition. Consider Munnaji's 'Rewaj'. In village life people call a widow a witch, yet after her death they compete to cremate her in order to secure her house site. The seed planted for the *vihani* tale here is of a somewhat higher order. The deceased person has no son, but leaves a wife and daughter. When the dead man's brother seeks to lift the bier, the widow stops him and asks the daughter to do so. Who will support this new custom beginning today? The answer comes: the childless. Jawaharlal Kashyap's 'Hammar May Tohar May' and 'Bhagwanak Bhagya' present their subjects with remarkable originality.

The numerical and qualitative growth of the Maithili *vihani* tale is a cause for rejoicing.

5. The Place of the Short Story in Prose Literature and Its Critical Theory

Abstract

In Maithili a long story is sometimes also called a novel. A long story can explore certain aspects of life in some detail, but the short story does not give its author such scope. It nevertheless gives considerably more room than the vihani tale. Maithili writers now live in villages and cities, at home and abroad. The range of subjects in the present collection reflects the environments inhabited by different sections of Maithili writers.

Keywords: prose · short story · place · critical theory · Maithili

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In Maithili a long story is sometimes also described as a novel. A long story examines certain aspects of life at length; a short story does not give its writer that much room, though it affords greater freedom than a *vihani* tale. Today, Maithili writers live in villages and towns, within the country and overseas. The variety of themes in the present collection represents the different environments of Maithili writers from every social stratum. Alongside the milieu of Mithila itself, the conflicts and problems of migrant Maithils call attention to the need for a distinct critical approach to the short story.

The critical theory of the short story: The Maithili short story has advanced far beyond 'Buchchi Dai' and 'Kaniya Kaki'. Old problems have taken new forms, and the contemporary Maithili short story delineates them. Feminism, postmodern absurdity, humour and satire, and a balance between subject matter and technique are shaping the form. Through a measured use of vocabulary, writers reach the roots of their subjects. Social mobility, industrialisation, and the political, social, economic and cultural difficulties of a new state after independence—its processes of change and integration—can sometimes be mutually contradictory. Psychological and educational processes matter in the development of community life. In villages of Mithila, a person's status remains tied to place and caste; in migration, these determinants may sometimes be overturned. Feminism and women's movements take different forms in Mithila and in the diaspora. The legal order ought to secure justice for poor and disadvantaged groups, but has failed to do so because justice remains insufficiently accessible. Yet political realignments, shaped by elections every five years, are doing something of this work. Marxism advocates social realism. Freud regards every person as mysterious, and reads the literary work as a means of analysing its creator; Neo-Freudianism, by contrast, places cultural rather than biological factors in the foreground.

New Criticism is grounded in detailed examination of the work. Postmodernism, existentialism and humanism are philosophical schools of thought. Philosophy formerly embraced science, history, social and political life, economics, the arts and language. As the sciences and arts developed separate specialisations, particularly in science, the mathematical and scientific aspects of philosophy narrowed towards mathematical logic. Philosophical methods of induction and deduction moved towards analytical methods. Marx, who was like a divine intervention for the world's poor, made the dialectical method the basis of his interpretation. What is now called 'discussion' or debate, involving thesis and counter-thesis, was already present in the methods of refutation and defence in Indian philosophy, particularly the six schools of thought (see Madhavacharya's *Sarvadarshanasamgraha*). Francis Fukuyama, who announced the end of history after the fall of communist government, has more recently stepped back from that declaration. He had assumed that with the end of Russian communism only one ideology would remain, that the conflict of ideas would cease, and therefore history itself would end. Now, however, he says that the ideologies of power and of the deprived remain different, and their conflict—and history—will continue. Postmodernism too has slowed after its initial enthusiasm. Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, Romanticism and sociological analysis have survived within synthetic modes of criticism. Psychoanalysis, because of its scientific basis, will continue to survive as the dialectical method has done.

Psychology, too, may provide the foundation of a short story. The aims of the form should change with the needs of society and the transformations occurring during its historical journey. At the same time, the story is inevitably shaped and constrained by that society's culture, through which its historical existence becomes manifest.

The postmodern perspective critiques the supposed completeness of scientific knowledge. Truth and falsehood are described from different viewpoints; there is self-centred humour, and even the distinction between good and bad may intermittently disappear. One cannot tell when truth may become falsehood. There is superficial reflection, neither optimism nor quite pessimism, and a kind of reckless caprice: the same object can be thought about in more than one way. Rather than trusting the results of reason, control and planning, this perspective relies more upon the outcomes of chance. Democratic and feminist standpoints, together with emblems such as the red flag, become subjects of playful treatment. Globalisation has brought questions concerning women and communities excluded from the mainstream to the attention of postmodernism. It has opposed ideology and universal goals without being able to offer an answer. Similarly, Jacques Derrida deconstructed language and demonstrated that its constituent parts depend upon numerous different

conditions, without understanding which its meaning cannot be established. A storyteller must nevertheless believe that dialogue can be restored—a belief grounded both in reason and in experience.

Analytical philosophy, or positivism, analyses linguistic propositions and concepts rather than objects. Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism emerged in reaction to science, clarifying ambiguities in scientific thinking. Phenomenology studies what is given to consciousness as it is given. Experience is an observation of the facts of particular mental acts, a means of seeing things impartially and in their pure form. For existentialism, a human being is nothing other than what that human being makes; there is nothing separate from this creation. The human being, in Sartre's words, is condemned to be free. Through the endless interaction of analysis and synthesis, Hegelian dialectics emphasised judgements about the qualities of processes and about existence. The deeper the essence, the further it may be from outward form and the nearer to reality.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also influenced modern thought. Invisible internal and external processes are made possible by exchanges among minute elements of force and energy. Under the uncertainty principle, position and form must be determined by approximation. The notion of a universe with more than three dimensions and Stephen Hawking's *A Brief History of Time* are, the author argues, directly undermining the existence of God and bringing the idea of God's death into view. Just as virtual reality artificially presents reality and joins consciousness to it, without positing more than three dimensions, even a journey at the speed of light begun in the age of the Indus Valley civilisation would not have reached the edge of the universe by today. Such scientific and philosophical ideas pose challenges to the short story. A synthesis of the holistic and the whole is needed; only then can philosophy become something real rather than merely philosophical.

Poststructuralist methodology locates the meaning of language not in dictionary meanings or grammatical rules, but in the process through which meaning is produced. Meaning varies across individuals and groups. There is no final correspondence between language and the world, nor one definitive meaning of a word or its text. Modernity arose through modern and postmodern argument, reality, dialogue and exchanges of ideas. Subsequently the New Left movement appeared in France, alongside tendencies such as nihilism and anarchism. These were grounded in distrust arising outside the belief systems and assumptions of modern thought. Hidden meanings in a text came to be interpreted in their temporal and spatial contexts, and language was treated as a game—a

'language game'. Postmodernism emerged as a critique of power, legitimacy and their hierarchies.

In the computer and information revolution, a programmer creates software and places it on the World Wide Web; the software continues to function independently of its maker and may perform tasks for which it was never designed. Interfering programs such as viruses divert it from its course and make it destructive. Antivirus software may repair the damage; if it cannot, a computer's contents are backed up and the system formatted —a clean slate. Capitalism arose from the Industrial Revolution, but the postindustrial society gives increasing importance to information and communication rather than production, and the computer's social role has expanded. Mobile phones, credit cards and similar objects rely on chips. Deconstruction and reconstruction point to the reorganisation of the processes of creation through which consciousness is being reconstituted in the postindustrial age. It is not history itself but traditional history that has ended. State, class, nation, party, society, family, morality and marriage are all being redefined. As a consequence of rapid changes, many institutions have fragmented and lost their contexts.

Michel Foucault says that knowledge and truth are constructed. Deleuze and Guattari say that we desire because we are desiring-machines. Mikhail Bakhtin treats language as a social activity. The Russian Formalists regard literature as a distinctive use of language. Jean-François Lyotard maintains that truth and historical truth are only apparent. Baudrillard argues that advertising and television have erased the distinction between the real and the imaginary. Both are major thinkers of postmodernism. Lacan's distinctive contribution was the linguistic application of Freud's methods. He argues that the unconscious is structured like a language: when a child learns language, the child learns a word for a sign. Lacan carefully considers desire, lack and the Other. Desire contains both need and demand, but cannot be divided into those two terms alone. In describing the Other, errors and absences appear. The subject is a momentary effect of meaning, and becomes like the Other when it is imaginary and creates a lack from which desire arises.

Three thinkers of postcolonialism are Homi Bhabha (close to Foucault and Lacan), Gayatri Spivak (close to Foucault and Derrida), and Edward Said (close to Foucault). They interpret the work and theorisation through which earlier colonial conceptions—such as the supposed cunning or indolence of the colonised—were established. Raymond Williams's cultural studies reveal the relationship between literature and economic conditions. New Historicism compares the textuality of history with the historicity of texts. Elaine Showalter identifies psychological, biological and linguistic features of women's writing. Simone de Beauvoir sees class

and caste as obstacles to women's solidarity with women, an interpretation challenged by later feminist theory. Virginia Woolf regards economic independence and privacy as essential for women writers, although her views have not been regarded as revolutionary. Mary Wollstonecraft urged a revolution in women's education and the inclusion of education in rational judgement.

Within New Criticism, Eliot opposed the dominance of personal emotion in poetry and argued for impersonality. Improving public taste is also part of a critic's task. Wimsatt and Beardsley held that criticism should not be based on the poet's intention or a historical inquiry, nor on the emotional effect upon readers, since this is relative. It should be based on the actual words of the text. The history of English criticism may be traced to Philip Sidney, who considered poetry in terms of beauty, meaning and human good. John Dryden considered moral instruction in ancient literature and its advantages and disadvantages. Samuel Johnson wrote about the comic and tragic elements of Shakespeare's drama. Rousseau's Romanticism does not doubt the essential goodness of human beings (the classical critics do, while neoclassical thinkers maintain that human nature is corrupt but institutions can improve it); at the same time, it holds that institutions are corrupt and assist only the corrupt.

Structuralism challenged modern positivism, which had left the status of literature unquestioned, and thereafter the writer lost exclusive authority over the interpretation of the text. Poststructuralism maintained that literature goes beyond what structuralism understands. Postmodernism is one form of poststructuralism. The latter argued that literary structures operate between culture and theory, while certain emotions and thoughts remain excluded and resist continuity. Deconstruction and postmodernism followed poststructuralism. Postcolonialism rejects new forms of colonial rule; the theory of disorder, similarly, views the failure of an intended aim as a reason for the absence of an appropriate outcome. Structuralism attacked oppressive Western systems and society, thereby strengthening Marxism (Althusser). After modernist positivism, New Criticism, structuralism and poststructuralism came deconstruction and postmodernism, described as the cultural logic of late capitalism (Fredric Jameson).

In the eighteenth century, 'modern' meant rootless, but by the early twentieth century it came to suggest progressivism. After 1970 the term became associated with a theoretical position, and 'postmodern' acquired a specific critical meaning in which the worldly ceased to be important. Life and history up to modernity became insignificant and were treated as finished. The theory became posthistorical, postdevelopmental and postcausal; truth and mutual connection lost their significance. In magical

realism, magical objects and events are introduced into a real situation, as writers experiment in order to understand reality more adequately. Postmodern Western bourgeois culture uses audiovisual media to reduce inequality, injustice and deprivation to mere words, alongside words such as equality, attainment and justice. Poverty, which the author describes as no longer a problem in the West, remains a grave problem in India today. Postmodernism opposes feminism and Marxism, and both feminism and Marxism have resisted it. Marxism's defence of historical analysis has strengthened its theory anew in the contexts of structuralism, poststructuralism and postmodernism. Although Marxism emphasises material life, it is not thereby identical with utilitarianism or Charvaka philosophy, which attend solely to physical needs. Feminist criticism has likewise opposed postmodern complacency with the status quo: women's situation will not improve until that complacency ends. **Plato:** Plato holds that no art can be good because art is false and unreal. This view should also be read against the military organisation of Athens in comparison with that of Sparta.

Dialogue can occur in two ways: through a formal address or through conversation. Conversation will contain fewer philosophical elements. Derrida's deconstructive method brings down works or writers accorded high rank and raises those placed below them. Roland Barthes writes that a work becomes important when it separates from its creator and begins to be analysed independently; he calls this the death of the author.

Poststructuralism overturned structuralism's claim to completeness and coherence. Saussure's theory of language—speech and writing, the textuality of an actual moment or of its historical setting, the importance of a particular work or person, significance as a concept, language in its present time or historical context—was itself unsettled by Derrida's deconstructive approach.

Sex is a biological fact, but the concepts of woman and man are socially produced. Literature and art concerning women have largely been made by men and view women through a male gaze. Feminist literary theory probes the roots of this problem. In Mithila the position of women is not so bad, the author argues, but the one-sided tendencies of Maithili literature have highlighted the difficulties faced by women of the upper classes. Modernisation has also worsened women's position among the so-called socially lower castes. Caste and religion, moreover, have divided women's rights into fragments. Feminist criticism maintains that theories made entirely by men cannot provide a complete explanation. Simple humanism emerged in opposition to theory, yet itself became a theory; meaningful literature has been produced within it.

Excessive criticism should be avoided. Critics ought not to turn reviews into exhibitions of their learning. In the course of criticising too much, people begin to display their erudition. Restraint is essential, and abusive vocabulary betrays the critic's poor upbringing. It is unethical to review a short story without reading it. For example, in *Karmadharaya*, Taranand Viyogi writes of Dhumketu's story 'Namaz-e-Shukrana': 'His story "Namaz-e-Shukrana" is highly significant in delineating the communal harmony established for ages in the culture of Mithila' (*Karmadharaya*, p. 127). (!) Such a review appears to have been written from the title alone. In the story, while Haji Sahib is offering prayers, a parrot in a cage cries 'Sita ... Ram ...'. Haji Sahib repeatedly hurls the cage against the mosque wall until the parrot dies. Saeeda begins to weep, and the story ends. Yet, in the critic's view, the story delineates communal harmony!

Critics must also avoid excessive praise. A review should demonstrate how a story differs from others on the same subject, what gap it fills, what it contains, and how it compares with other stories dealing with that theme. Taking account of the short story's limited compass, a review ought to be about a thousand words long. It should be a review of the story, not its author. Filling it with analysis of the writer's other works does not make for good criticism; introduce those works only when they bear a direct relationship to the story at hand. Given Mithila's varied cultures and history—and especially the one-sided condition of Maithili literature—there has also been a tradition of personal attacks and attention to district and locality. Caste, religion and regionalism rarely appear explicitly in Maithili criticism, but reviewers are strongly influenced by an insistence on praising or condemning writers according to personal friendship and hostility. Ask whether a review actually illuminates the story. Is it simply commenting upon the writer or the writer's other work? A close reading will reveal whether the story was read before the review was written. The age of ornamental critical language is over. Use precise words; remove unnecessary words and lines. A review of an autobiographical short story may legitimately throw light on the author's life. Keep misogyny and mental attitudes bounded by caste or region out of short-story criticism.

In creating a short story's atmosphere, the author develops descriptions of its characters, its structure, the people and the circumstances necessary to it. A short story may also be written by taking just one of these elements. The critic should establish how a work is excellent and what it has omitted. Evaluation must not be one-sided. The reviewer should understand and explain the message concealed in it and the direction in which the author is pointing. Identify the story's main current. Do not impose your own ideology upon the work under review. Show why the story is needed in the present day, in what its importance consists, and what its principal elements are. Identify the writer's philosophy of life, the

writer's view of reality, imagination and ideals, and the uncertainties within that view. Discuss the artistic features of the author's style, the ability to tell a story, the architecture of the work, and the art of joining its parts. One carpenter makes a bed that is both sturdy and beautiful; another concentrates only on strength, and a third on beauty. The same differences exist in literary art.

Why is theory necessary? Simple humanism says that instead of applying literary theory, one may use ordinary reason to determine a work's human perspective and whether it has significance. By exercising one's own intelligence one can judge its quality; no literary theory is necessary for criticism.

Some of Maithili's Finest Short Stories

Meena Jha's 'Breast Cancer' addresses a problem affecting women, and one might have expected a woman to write a story with such psychological insight on the subject. Yet no woman had written a short story on it until then. The description of the husband's state of mind after his wife's breast-cancer operation is exact. Roshan Janakpuri bears direct witness to the struggles of the deprived; Jagdish Prasad Mandal presents the same struggle in a different form, and Mahaprakash, too, communicates it through a short-story narrative. Vasant Bhagwant Sawant's Konkani story 'Rozi Roti' concerns the struggle of emotional life against the demands of livelihood. Prabhat Rai Bhatt tells a comparable story in another setting with even greater pathos. Binu Bhai is a master of analysis and clarifies the ideas associated with his subject through his vocabulary. Shambhu Kumar Singh writes about the condition of Maithili, whereas Anmol Jha, Satyanarayan Jha and Om Prakash Jha deal with village and household life, employment, and the worlds inside and outside the home.

Turning to love stories, Durganand Mandal's 'Lal Bhauji', Sujit Kumar Jha's 'Ekta Adhikar', Kailash Kumar Mishra's 'Chanda', Pankaj Kumar Priyanshu's 'Jeevank Anmol Kshan', Amit Mishra's 'Prem Nai Jahar Chhai', Kamini's 'Mayi Nahi Tutal Tara', and Rajnath Mishra's 'Masti' are straightforward love stories. Yet each differs from the others in its distinctive treatment of humour, seriousness and feudalism. Asgar Wajahat comments upon communal riots, Rajdev Mandal upon elections; Virendra Kumar Yadav, Satish Chandra Jha and Atuleshwar examine different dimensions of social problems. Umesh Mandal, Navin Thakur, Kishan Karigar, Shiv Kumar Jha and Bacheśwar Jha are opening new directions for satire. Nand Vilas Rai and Kapileshwar Raut first intermingle satire and social problems through a magic of language, and then separate them. Santosh Kumar Mishra's 'Musibat' and Ashish Anchinhar's 'Katal Katha' are instances of postmodern absurdity. Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi' becomes entangled in the conflict between tradition and

modernity ('Devavani'). In 'Ghaswali', Manoj Kumar Mandal writes about women's struggles, while Shambhunath Jha 'Vats' links those struggles with the terror of floods to tell an unforgettable story.

The breadth of subject and technique attained by the Maithili short story is a source of delight.

6. The Place of the Novel in Prose Literature and Its Critical Theory

Abstract

The beginnings of the novel: *Banabhatta's Kadambari opens with a description of King Shudraka's city of Vidisha. An exceptionally beautiful Chandala girl arrives at the royal court with a learned parrot named Vaishampayana, and the parrot's story begins. In the Chandala settlement of Pakkana there are no beggars or thieves; its ruler, Vyaghradeva, himself twists rope.*

Keywords: novel · is · place · are · fiction · prose · critical theory

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The beginnings of the novel: Banabhatta's *Kadambari* begins with a description of Vidisha, the city of King Shudraka. An exceptionally beautiful Chandala girl brings a wise parrot named Vaishampayana into court, whereupon the parrot's tale begins. In the Chandala settlement of Pakkana there is neither beggar nor thief, and the local king, Vyaghradeva, himself twists ropes. From the name of this Sanskrit novel comes the Marathi word *kadambari* for a novel. Despite the bourgeois beginnings of the novel, it has attained such complexity that it provides a searching test of literary talent. Because of the genre's bourgeois origins, it was only shortly before the nineteenth century that the novel acquired a serious form, notwithstanding the earlier appearance of Cervantes's *Don Quixote* at the beginning of the seventeenth century. In the novel, debate and dialogue give rise to the essay; the depiction of young men and women generates romance; people and geography provide the materials for historical description; and accounts of good and bad characters come forward. At times it makes readers laugh, at others it instructs them. Marxism advocates the novel's representation of social reality. Freud considers all human beings mysterious and makes the literary work a means of analysing the author, while Neo-Freudianism emphasises cultural rather than biological factors. New Criticism is based on close and detailed consideration of the work. Alongside these elements, lived experience itself represents only one side of existence. To satisfy repressed desires, the novelist creates a world in which readers walk along the boundary between reality and imagination.

The novel and ideology: Postmodernism, existentialism and humanism are philosophical schools of thought. In earlier times philosophy encompassed science, history, society, politics, economics, aesthetics and language. As its scientific and artistic branches became specialised, particularly the sciences, the place of mathematics and science within philosophy became restricted to mathematical logic. Philosophical inquiry

through induction and deduction turned towards analytical methods. Marx, who was like a divine intervention for the world's poor, based his interpretation upon the dialectical method.

The beginnings and development of the novel: In the English novel *The Pilgrim's Progress*, the author describes the protagonist's journey, together with its struggles and moments of enthusiasm.

Literary Vocabulary

An author's ideology should be like salt dissolved in water, not oil floating on it; I have written about this before. Yatri and Dhumketu needed the crutches of the Communist Party because, for them, leftism was a fashion, like a good scent or designer clothes. Thus Balchanma, after turning away from the Congress and the Socialist Party, seeks a solution to every problem in communism and the red flag, and Yatri supplies him with every answer in those terms. For Dhumketu's characters too, the red flag is a life-restoring herb, a *Lakshman-buti*. But these writers were not engaged in the communist movement beyond the level of fashion; consequently ideology floats conspicuously over their literature like oil.

Now consider the Maithili writing of Chaturanand Mishra and Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Have you found the red flag or the Communist Party mentioned anywhere in Chaturanand Mishra's novels or Jagdish Prasad Mandal's literary works? What we find instead is the genuine left-wing dialectical method and faith in life itself: ideology dissolved like salt. Is it merely a coincidence that Chaturanand Mishra wrote literature in the early part of his life, whereas Jagdish Prasad Mandal began in later life, after the last legal case against him had ended? Thakurji, the landlord of Mandal's village Berma, told my paternal cousin that Jagdish Prasad Mandal was a truthful Harishchandra and the pride of their village. This was said of a man who had led the communist movement, been jailed ten times, and fought legal cases against the landlords—with the result that today no one in Berma holds more than ten bighas of agricultural land.

Even now he rises at three in the morning, lights his small lamp and writes Maithili literature. His son has never seen him writing and does not know when he writes. Under Bhogendra Jha's leadership, Mandal had vowed that whenever he spoke he would speak only in Maithili; his son has never heard him speak another language. This is why his subject matter is fresh and his vocabulary is that of a native speaker, capable of expressing—and necessary to—the subject at hand. His people, trees, plants, flowers, fields and threshing grounds are real, rooted in the earth, not artificially excavated from some subterranean store. Writers of the new generation living outside Mithila should draw inspiration from him and learn the

region's history, geography and culture before writing in Maithili. Only then can their literature acquire its own distinct character.

Pseudo-standardisation: This is the result of favouring the ideas of one particular caste-centred school, reflected in one or two Maithili books published by the Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL) and in a standardisation project that has continued for years without producing results.

Genuine standardisation: A standard Maithili created through extensive discussion and deliberation, grounded in the Maithili spoken by every caste in every region of Mithila.

Benipuri's *Ambapali* is a play in Hindi and has been included by NCERT in the school curriculum. The editors, however, have pointed out that the absence of the verb *hai* in expressions such as *vah ja raha* reflects the influence of Benipuri's local region. Respecting its historical character, the editorial board has not altered the text even though it appears in the school syllabus.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal's long story *Shambhudas* has appeared. Consider its second paragraph:

'Just as fallow land amid the fields and woods, untouched by plough or spade, may dry up until its trees fall and the soil grows barren, yet on that same land, through birds or through wind and water, wild fruit-bearing trees may spring up, face sun and wind, rain and stones, darkness and storm, attain their youth, and spread their chests to satisfy passing travellers with their sweet taste—so was Shambhudas born into a sharecropping peasant family on the bank of the Jamuna River.'

Is there any need to add *achhi* ('is') after *jait* ('going') or *karait* ('doing') here?

Theory and practice: A closer look suggests that a novelist's work attempts to carry the ideologies and viewpoints of its time. Yet particular qualities arise on their own in the passage from theory to practice. This is true of the Maithili novel as well. In Ramanand Renu's novels it is clearly visible in the technique. Lily Ray's extraordinary ability to describe the events, society and politics around her through the sharpness of her pen goes a step beyond English novels. Lalit, Yatri and Dhumketu place economic and social problems before readers without concealing their particulars. Saketanand depicts the problem of floods. Harimohan Jha brings currents of English literature into his own style and makes them apparent even in the syllabus that a male protagonist gives the heroine to study.

Chaturanan Mishra and Jagdish Prasad Mandal were practically involved in the communist movement and in party organisation. Yet after reading

their novels I have no hesitation in saying that, whereas Yatri and Dhumketu need the crutch of Marxism to make their novels stand, these two novelists do not. The true meaning of Marxism can be found in their work. There is no mention of party names or ideologies, but there is a recognition of genuine dialectical materialism, a belief in the importance of life, and the use of the dialectical method. This becomes possible only when the writer undertakes a profound study of Marxism, including *Das Kapital*.

In most living languages, novels form a large part of literary production; in Maithili, however, comparatively few novels are written. As increasing numbers of the younger generation enter Maithili literature after studying English language and literature, Maithili writing will be able to deepen its social, economic, political and cultural insights. Kedarnath Chaudhary's *Chameli Rani*, *Mahur*, *Karar*, *Hina*, *Ayna* and *Abara Nahitan* confirm this view.

7. Literature for Infants, Children and Adolescents, and Its Critical Theory

Abstract

Children's literature broadly encompasses writing for infants younger than one year through adolescents up to eighteen years of age. For children whose learning progresses more slowly, the age categories may differ somewhat: material regarded as suitable for a typical six-year-old, for instance, may be used with such children at ten years of age …

Keywords: infants · children · adolescents · critical theory · Maithili

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Children's literature broadly includes works intended for infants younger than one year and for adolescents up to the age of eighteen. For children whose intellectual development or learning progresses more slowly, the age groups may need to be defined differently. For example, what is considered children's literature for a typical six-year-old may be appropriate for them at the age of ten.

The Saraswati River, the great flood, the narratives of Manu and the Great Fish, the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, Gilgamesh's quest for the land of the living, creation stories and the development of systems of gods—all these, in relation to the *Rigveda*, the *Avesta* and other sources, may be regarded as early children's literature. The spoked chariot is described in the Vedas; according to the author, it was not then found in Western Asia or Europe. Indian divine names, crafts, narratives, the science of horses, music, linguistic elements and modes of thought began to appear in Western Asia, Egypt and Greece. In the second millennium BCE, spoked chariots, Indian divine names, currents of Indian thought, Rigvedic philosophy, horsemanship, craft technologies and ancient narratives began to move from India towards Western Asia, Crete and Greece. Much of the *Rigveda*, the author maintains, had been composed well before the cultures of Egypt, Sumer and Babylonia, or those of the Mitanni and Hittites, emerged in the relevant chronology. Language must have existed before the *Rigveda*, the oldest surviving work of Vedic Sanskrit. Oral literature such as *gatha*, *narashamsi*, stories of the gods and other narratives may have been composed in that language. The *Rigveda* uses terms such as *gathin*, *gatuvid* and *gathapati* for singers of such narratives. A celebrated story is drawn from history and the Puranas, while an invented story is imagined. Alongside Vedic narratives, Jataka tales, Aesop's fables, the *Panchatantra* and the *Hitopadesha*, folk ballads continued to circulate. Everywhere the tales of the elite coexist with folk narratives. Take the story of Salhesh: as it crosses regional boundaries, Salhesh changes from

king to thief and from thief to king. Likewise, Chuharmal is considered a thief where Salhesh is a king, but is known as a king or powerful figure in places where Salhesh is called a thief.

Beyond traditional narrative and balladry, the history of modern fiction takes us to the end of the nineteenth century, when it was recognised in forms such as the short story, tale and prose fiction. Beginning with Rabindranath Tagore, this journey spread from one end of India to the other under the influence of reformist movements. Vedic narrative, if we consider it, sets out love for the nation and teaches people to live together in society. Jataka stories, along with the spread of vernacular languages, also intended to spread Buddhism. By narrating through birds and animals, they offered a conception of children's literature long before the *Panchatantra* and the *Hitopadesha*. Just as Vishnu Sharma, in narrating the *Panchatantra*, can become needlessly cruel towards women and Shudras, so too, in the author's view, can the *Ramcharitmanas*. Aesop was an enslaved man in Greece who told stories to his master's children, and these became world-famous as Aesop's fables. The fox who, unable to obtain the grapes, declares that they must be sour has become immortal in storytelling.

In the Muslim world, Rumi's *Masnavi* is a distinctive work of Persian literature, teaching the importance of knowledge and the advancement of the state. Not everyone who reads a story will become enlightened, but at least they can enjoy wholesome entertainment. If even one reader begins thinking in the intended direction, the story has proved its worth. And if those for whom a story was written do not read it, others capable of intervening in their circumstances may do so. But when society changes, do social values remain eternal? Should progressive stories reconstruct experience for a changing society, so that natural and social realities may be brought into alignment? Or does a changing age need stories built upon the abiding elements of tradition to lend it stability? Individual and collective interests contain a duality and can conflict; they require reconciliation and a comprehensive worldview. A story is not merely an idea hastily transcribed onto paper in ink. It is shaped by social and historical conditions. Experience must therefore be recreated through narrative, and individual consciousness can then become social and collective consciousness. The oppressor must restrain the impulse to oppress; the oppressed must speak out forcefully against it. The story must be ordered and accessible if it is to achieve this purpose, becoming practical rather than merely intellectual. The openness of Vedic narrative gave rise to dialogue, which the dogmatism of Puranic literature extinguished.

This Sun is a mediocre star among countless billions and trillions of suns. On one of the planets of this unexceptional star—Earth—we live in a

town or village, holding our heads in anxiety and asking whose troubles could possibly be greater than ours. Such scientific and philosophical facts confront our storytelling as a challenge. Restoring dialogue requires conviction in the storyteller: conviction grounded in reasoning and experience. The practice of praising oneself and one's associates while disparaging others obstructs the creation of excellent children's literature. Reliance on the government, ignorance of priorities, and the desire among writers and critics to become great or make others great have taken hold at a time when the language itself is dying. There is no clear plan of action, and everyone anxiously attempts some isolated measure for Maithili. Those who do not speak Maithili themselves have in effect begun a campaign to distance their children from it. The media, cartoon channels, the educational system and large-scale migration within a single generation have all contributed. Because Maithili activists are divided among several poles, there is no effective lobby capable of building broad support. People worry more about what they or their own group will gain in return. The shortage of students of Maithili is compounded by poor marketing skills, even when a product is good. In Maithili, both good products and the ability to market them are in short supply.

Children's Literature and Its Criticism in the Maithili Context

I request writers for children to use the letters ङ (*ṅa*) and ञ (*ña*) correctly, so that children can learn more easily. Write भाङ, not भांग. In a workshop, children were observed reading छनि and कहलनि as छ नी and कहलनी respectively. Therefore use forms such as छन्हि and कहलन्हि. Careful use of conjunct consonants and ङ in Maithili writing for children will help preserve the language's distinctive character.

Use simple but authentically Maithili words, such as *akadarun*. Prose and verse are both important in children's literature; one might even say verse is more so. When prose stories incorporate subjects such as science and social science, they can reconcile education with entertainment. In Maithili a children's story may continue for an entire night, while a tale intended for adults can finish in minutes. There is a shortage of comics, picture stories and books on science, social studies, spirituality, physics, chemistry, biology and health in Maithili. Education is not being provided through evening schools, drawing and music. There is a particularly urgent need for Maithili teaching through distance education and the internet. Yet everyone carries a passion for Maithili in the heart, even when they oppose one another. People respect its rises and falls of intonation and distinctive linguistic features; among them are linguists who cannot themselves speak Maithili. Maithili is also important for its spiritual and cultural significance. It has an inner strength. Numerous organisations,

including some casteist and communal ones, are eager for its development. Speakers of the language live not only in India and Nepal but are now spread across other countries and regions.

It is said of Shankaracharya that he gathered a river's current into his water-pot. What happened, according to this account, was that a mountain in the middle of a flooded area caused flooding on one side and drought on the other. With his disciples' help, Shankara broke through the intervening cave. When he emerged carrying his water-pot, people saw water flowing to the other side. They praised him: 'You have brought the current into your water-pot and saved us from drought and the people on the other side from floods. You carried the water's support in your pot!' Later, opportunists turned the event into a miracle. I hope writers of Maithili children's literature will likewise interpret the story of Ugana through both reason and faith.

From Gonu Jha's village, Bharaura, comes the folk narrative of the boatman-hero Prince Dulara Dayal, 'Bahura Godhin Natua Dayal'. His shrine still stands in Bharaura. Children's writers should look beyond Gonu Jha to figures such as these. Tragedy contains plot, characterisation, verbal composition, thought, scenic arrangement and song. I do not support the view that children's literature must never contain tragedy. Children must also be taught how the folk deities of lower or formerly untouchable groups themselves came to be treated as untouchable. But it must be explained in a way that enables children to recognise and honour their heritage. Mithila's folk narratives, in the author's account, are not grounded in caste hierarchy or communalism. If Muslims had not yet arrived in Mithila in Gonu Jha's time, why are stories of a Muslim revenue officer's oppression inserted into the tales of Gonu Jha?

In the computer and information revolution, a software designer makes a program and places it on the World Wide Web. The program then operates independently of its designer, sometimes performing functions for which it was never intended. Interfering programs such as viruses can divert it and render it destructive. Antivirus software may repair it; otherwise, after taking a backup, one reformats the computer—a clean slate. Children's literature is similarly a kind of software inscribed upon the child's mind, but there is no option to reformat that mind. Creation of children's literature therefore demands vigilance and care.

Children's literature should be classified and reviewed by age: infancy (0–5 years), childhood (5–12 years) and adolescence (12–18 years). Picture books are made for children under five and are read to them by parents before they begin school. As adults read, children experience the stories through images, with rapid mental development as a result. Once children start school and learn the alphabet, they begin reading these books for

themselves alongside textbooks and other illustrated works. After seven they take up books with short chapters; by nine or ten, books with longer chapters; and after twelve, children's novels. Traditional folk tales and stories from history and the epics are told to children. Adventurous and inspiring biographies and ethically instructive narratives also belong to children's literature. Fairy tales, magic and songs can all contribute to meaningful writing for the young.

Criticism must therefore attend to the type of children's literature under consideration. Is it encouraging superstition? Does it help children recognise their inheritance? Will it foster a knowledge of human values? Does it succeed in teaching resistance to casteism and ideological extremism? Is the ideological balance being disturbed? Has dogmatism, deliberately or inadvertently, entered the child's healthy entertainment? Simple vocabulary, simple language and clear ideas will be the touchstones of excellence in children's literature.

Some of Maithili's Finest Works for Children

Kashyap Kamal's *Babuak Sunael Khissa*—including 'Sahasramukhak Deep', 'Gappak Artha', 'Jahiyasam Kal Dhelak', 'Neek Kari Ta Paigh Ke? Bejae Kari Ta Paigh Ke?', 'Parh Beta Nai Kari Okara Gun Bo Kari' and 'Akilak Mol'—along with Anil Mallik's *Dadik Geet* and Archana Kumar's *Dadi Sa Sunal Katha* ('Vidwan'), fill gaps in Maithili folk tales and songs. Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu' shows a profound grasp of child psychology in *Taregan Dekhaiye*, *Dahik Thop* and *Khonichak Lel Sari*. Durganand Mandal's story *Paras* is based on a real person and shows what can be accomplished through indomitable will. Vrishesh Chandra Lal's story *Golba* and Jagadanand Jha 'Manu's' children's novel *Chonha* are priceless possessions of Maithili children's literature; both display remarkable psychological insight. Vrishesh Chandra Lal also sings beautiful poems for children.

Pankaj Kumar Jha's *Mae Ge Mae* and Chandan Kumar Jha's two *Agadam-Bagadam* poems are sung with extraordinary simplicity. Both writers are engineers intimately acquainted with village culture. Sanskriti Verma, a fourth-standard student, is troubled by the burden of schoolbags, parental pressures and information technology, and expresses her feelings in writing. The children's poems of Manoj Kumar Mandal, Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu', Rajesh Mohan Jha 'Gunjan', Naresh Kumar Vikal, Ramakant Rai 'Rama' and Mahakant Thakur have fluency. Yet, when judged against children's mental world, Chandrashekhar Kamat surpasses them in fluency and feeling.

In Munni Kamat's *Patra*, a child says: 'I won't eat vegetables or bread. I don't want bread to eat. But, Mother, please let me go to study.' The same

longing for education appears in Chandan Kumar Jha's *Hamahu Parhabai Ab*. Shambhunath Jha teaches Newton's principles in Maithili. Prabhat Rai Bhatt's *Chunmun Chunmun Karait Chiriya* beautifully joins feeling and language. The field also includes Devanshu Vats's *Pragatik Rahasya*, as well as artwork by Tunisha Priyam, Gunjan Karna, Ganesh Thakur, Anupama Priyadarshini, Shweta Jha Chaudhary and Shweta Jha (Singapore). Shweta Jha Chaudhary's Mithila paintings are incomparable.

This children's festival has brought greater clarity to Maithili literature for the young. I hope that children will continue to use it as a kind of picnic for the coming year.

8. A Theory of Translation for Maithili and the Criticism of Translated Literature

Abstract

The account of Kshemendra's Kathamanjari or Somadeva's Kathasaritsagara as translations of Gunadhya's Brihatkatha, composed in the Paishachi language, might itself be a mode of storytelling, but it certainly marks an early stage in the history of translation. That history is very old. As masterpieces in ancient languages such as Sanskrit, Avestan, Greek and Latin became difficult to understand, readers felt a need for commentaries and, later, for translations into other languages. In the ancient Mauryan empire, Emperor Ashoka disseminated his stone inscriptions, in a particular language and script, throughout the regions of his state and country. Commentaries were first written in the original language, and only later in other languages.

Keywords: translation · theory · translated · literature · criticism · Maithili

The story that Kshemendra's *Kathamanjari* or Somadeva's *Kathasaritsagara* was translated from Gunadhya's Paishachi *Brihatkatha* may itself belong to a storytelling tradition, but it certainly represents the beginning of a history of translation.

Translation has a very long history. When a classic work in an ancient language such as Sanskrit, Avestan, Greek or Latin began to seem difficult, the need arose to write commentaries on it and, a little later, to translate it into another language in order to understand it. The stone inscriptions of Emperor Ashoka of the ancient Mauryan empire were disseminated throughout different regions of the state and country in a particular script and language. At first commentaries were written in the original language; later they came to be written in other languages.

Principles for translation from Maithili into other languages, and from other languages into Maithili: Direct translation from Maithili into another language has so far largely been limited to Sanskrit, Bengali, Nepali, Hindi and English. Translation directly into Maithili also takes place from these five languages. Some direct translation has been done from Marathi, Malayalam and other languages, but this is negligible in quantity. Translation both into Maithili and out of Maithili frequently employs one of those five languages as an intermediary. Even among them, Sanskrit and Bengali are used comparatively little as relay languages; Hindi, Nepali and English are more common. Adaptation is somewhat different from translation: a story may be adapted for the stage, or prose turned into verse and verse into prose. Such a change of genre may take place within Maithili itself. Without a knowledge of translation theory,

the adapter may distort both meaning and feeling. The problem becomes even more serious in translation into or from Maithili.

Some essential elements of good translation: When translating word for word, consider whether the underlying sense of an idiom or context is being carried over. Attend to the preservation of the words, sentences and construction of the language. If the original employs archaic words, the translated text should also favour older, authentic vocabulary. A wide knowledge of the grammar and lexical resources of both languages is essential. In the original language, Ramnath or Umesh may be addressed with an emphatically affectionate or familiar vocative. In such a case it could be appropriate to translate the address as *Ramnathahun* or *Umeshahun*, rather than an uninflected *Ramnath* or *Umesh*, although that would not be appropriate under ordinary circumstances. Correspondence is required in word, feeling, form, and the language appropriate to the place and period of the original work.

The translator must know both the source and target languages, but also the history, geography, folk tales, proverbs, rural and forest life, and urban cultures of both language regions. This becomes still more important in translation through an intermediary language. Here, the requisite knowledge of 'the history, geography, folk tales, proverbs, and rural, forest and urban cultures of both language regions' refers to the original and target language regions, not the region of the intermediary language. Sometimes a linguistic or nonlinguistic element (a cultural element) in the source has no exact equivalent in the target language. The translator may then begin to explain it at length or supply some approximate term. In such a case, it is better to explain the matter fully or clarify it in an appendix than to provide a misleading approximation. This can reduce the literary loss incurred when a text is translated from its original language through an intermediate one.

The translation of stories, poems, plays, novels, epics (narrative poems), essays, school and college textbooks, and books on computer science, sociology, social science and natural science requires particular techniques. Essays, textbooks and writing in the sciences and social sciences are in one respect easier to translate: they discuss their subjects in detail and, unlike imaginative writing—stories, poems, plays, novels and epics—usually have fewer or no complex layers of feeling and cultural inflection. Their readership, too, is arranged by class or subject. Chemical names, biological and botanical binary names, and symbols accepted by specialised international organisations should neither be changed nor translated.

Among creative genres, drama is the most difficult to translate, followed by poetry and then fiction. In drama the translator must recognise the background and indirect implications of the play and understand the

psychology of its characters. In poetry it is essential to know the genre and formal structure of the poem. For example, translating a Maithili haiku into English by matching Maithili's five-seven-five pattern of letters to the number of letters in English produces an absurd result, because English haiku conventionally use a five-seven-five syllabic pattern, and the relation between letters and syllables is not the same in English as in Maithili. In this regard, Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary's translations from Maithili into English offer a model. One must consider rhythm and imagery, and relate each part of the poem to the structure of the whole. In fiction, the translator must understand the author, characters, narrative sequence, the time frame of flashbacks and the setting. Consider epic translation: Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* translates an Awadhi work into Maithili, preserving the classical forms of *doha*, *chaupai* and *soratha.*

The British rulers introduced the teaching of Sanskrit by means of translation. Latin and Greek were not taught in this way. If you learn Sanskrit or another language through this method, you may become a scholar or an expert, but you will not necessarily be able to converse in it. Only by learning a language as a mother tongue will you develop conversational ability. A curriculum may introduce its culture through dictionaries, illustrative tales, history and geography.

Translation by computer: Computers are used experimentally to translate imaginative writing, essays, school and college books, and works in computer science, sociology, social science and natural science. Yet 'cold-blooded animal' can be rendered absurdly as a 'ruthless creature'. Computer translation has nevertheless succeeded in certain areas. On Wikipedia, translating a list of five hundred frequently used words and another vocabulary list of 2,600 words; in Google's translation tools, translating basic terms; and in other collaborative projects such as Mozilla Firefox, translating English technical computer terminology—these activities can make automatic Maithili translation possible with few or no errors.

9. Poetry and Its Critical Theory

Abstract

Literature has two forms: prose and poetry. Composition governed by metre is called poetry; what is not so governed is prose. Chhand (metre) is understood as a form of composition that gives pleasure. Harimohan Jha writes "A Poem's Utterance to Non-Poetry," while Gopal Ji Jha "Gopesh," in "O Cuckoo of Poetry, Had You Lived in the Present Age," declares, "I would have written it myself, and I alone would have understood it." Each thus makes his position clear.

Keywords: poetry · critical theory · Maithili

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Literature has two forms: prose and poetry. Composition governed by metre is called poetry; what is not so governed is prose. *Chhand* (metre) is understood as a form of composition that gives pleasure. Harimohan Jha writes "A Poem's Utterance to Non-Poetry," while Gopal Ji Jha "Gopesh," in "O Cuckoo of Poetry, Had You Lived in the Present Age," declares, "I would have written it myself, and I alone would have understood it." Each thus makes his position clear. This must not, however, be taken to mean that new poetry today belongs to the category of prose. Even the Vedic Sāvitrī mantra, in the Gāyatrī metre, is counted as Gāyatrī because the rules permit a degree of flexibility: where syllables are deficient, one or two can be supplied in each *pāda*; the conjuncts involving *ya* and *va* can be separated by inserting *i* and *u*, respectively. Thus *vareṇyam* becomes *vareṇiyam*, and *svaḥ* becomes *suvaḥ*.

A critical theory of Maithili poetry: The critic must consider a poem's rhythm and imagery, and must also examine how its individual sections relate to its central body. The Maithili language and its writing system are especially well suited to contemporary new poetry and to haiku. Both syllabic (*vārṇik*) and quantitative (*mātrik*) metrical arrangements are effective in the ghazal and the *rubāī*. An *āzād ghazal* may also be written without a *bahr* (metre). No composition is intrinsically irrelevant; if it profoundly stirs you, how could it be without significance?

Plato argues that art cannot be good because it is untrue and unreal. His position should also be read in light of his observation of the shortcomings of the Athenian military organisation in comparison with Sparta. He opposed poetry and drama insofar as the memorisation and recitation of dialogue might attract people towards an artificial life. Aristotle, on the other hand, did not regard poetry merely as imitation; he also perceived philosophy and universal truth in it. In ancient Greece poetry was regarded as a message from the gods. Aristophanes

distinguished good and bad poetry; Theophrastus recognised three kinds —severe, excellent, and grand. Poetry and music are inseparable. Yet the European symphony, in which numerous instruments may perform together in different rhythmic patterns, introduced a difference in theoretical understanding.

English literary criticism may be traced to Philip Sidney, who considered poetry in relation to beauty, meaning and human welfare. In New Criticism, Eliot opposed the predominance of emotion in poetry and urged impersonality. Romanticism, by contrast, speaks of poetry as personal experience. In the context of structuralism and poststructuralism, Barthes considers the 'death of the author' necessary to free the reader from the author's intention: the author is separated from the composition, and the reader searches for meaning independently.

In magical realism, magical elements enter real situations; through this technique writers seek to understand reality more fully. The author argues that the Western postmodern bourgeois use of audiovisual media reduces inequality, injustice and deprivation to mere words placed beside equality, possession and justice. Poverty, which in the author's account is not a problem in the West, remains a major problem in India. In this account, postmodernism stands in opposition to feminism and Marxism, and both have resisted it. Marxism, committed to historical analysis, has renewed its theory in the context of structuralism, poststructuralism and postmodernism. Although it emphasises the material world, Marxism is not thereby identical with utilitarianism or Cārvāka philosophy, which the author describes as attending only to bodily necessities. Feminist criticism likewise opposes the status-quo orientation attributed here to postmodernism, since the condition of women cannot improve so long as that condition endures.

After modernist positivism, New Criticism, structuralism and poststructuralism came deconstruction and postmodernism, associated with 'late capitalism' (Fredric Jameson). Structuralism challenged the modern positivist position, which did not question the status of literature, and subsequently deprived authors of exclusive authority to analyse the texts they themselves had written. Structuralism attacks the oppressive organisation of Western society; in this respect, Marxism gained strength (Althusser). Poststructuralism holds that literature exceeds what structuralism understands it to be. Postmodernism is one form of poststructuralism. Poststructuralism argues that literary structures operate within culture and theory, where certain feelings and ideas are excluded and contest continuity. Deconstruction and postmodernism followed poststructuralism. Postcolonialism rejects new forms of colonialism and

treats the failure of particular objectives to produce appropriate outcomes in terms comparable to a theory of disorder.

Indian conceptions of poetry: Consider the idea of art directed towards *mokṣa* (liberation), exemplified by the posture of Naṭarāja. The rhythms of creation and destruction are both visible in it. A durable emotion (*sthāyibhāva*) intensifies and matures into *rasa*; Sītā and Rāma experienced many such *rasas* (see the Vālmīki Rāmāyaṇa). Kṛṣṇa is a teacher of the Indian philosophy of action, but also a connoisseur of aesthetic experience. The theory of *rasa* became necessary to account for the enjoyment of art, and Bharata composed the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Abhinavagupta wrote a commentary on Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka*. Bhāmaha in the sixth century, Daṇḍin in the seventh, and Rudraṭa in the ninth carried these discussions forward.

The theory of rasa: For Bharata, *rasa* arises through the effect of drama. What is drama for? It both enacts *rasa* and brings it into being. How does *rasa* arise? Through its causes (*vibhāvas*), its consequent manifestations (*anubhāvas*), and accompanying or transitory states (*vyabhicāribhāvas*). A lasting emotional disposition deepens and matures into a *rasa* that we can savour. For Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa, a lasting disposition becomes *rasa* through this process of cause and effect. Actors experience it through investigation and imagination. Lollaṭa does not assign comparable importance to the poet or to the listener and spectator. Śaunaka holds that the spectator must enter imaginatively into the performance to experience *rasa*, just as one may respond to a picture of a horse as if it were a horse. Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka maintains that the effect of *rasa* is experienced by the audience, and distinguishes the poet's language from ordinary language. Through *rasa*, the soul of the listener or spectator meets the Supreme Self. Its delight is the bliss of one's own true nature (*svarūpānanda*), bringing self-realisation. The theory of *rasa* is thus based upon, and gives particular importance to, listeners, spectators and readers.

The theory of dhvani: In the *Dhvanyāloka*, Ānandavardhana holds that literature's purpose is to convey meaning indirectly or to generate meaning. The theory accounts for the structure and operation of suggested meaning, the experience of beauty called *rasa*, and the theory of figures of speech. For Ānandavardhana, *dhvani*—suggestion—is the soul of poetry. Meaning comes indirectly through suggestion, yet in an organised form; questions of meaning and symbol emerge from this process. Suggestion produces the effect of *rasa* and brings *rasa* into being. Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā opposed this theory, arguing that *dhvani* has no independent existence, being instead an outcome of inference already included under secondary indication (*lakṣaṇā*), and that everything cannot be expressed through words.

The theory of sphoṭa: Bhartṛhari's *Vākyapadīya* maintains that the meaning of a word or sentence is communicated through *sphoṭa*. The phonemic, verbal and sentential forms of *sphoṭa* account respectively for phonemes, words and sentences. No knowledge is possible without a relationship to words; this became a part of Indian epistemology. Meaning can be communicated without the individual letters, words and sentences existing together as a single simultaneous utterance. *Sphoṭa* is *śabdabrahman*, the principle of language as ultimate reality and the primary cause of creation. Letters, words and sentences do not all remain present at the same moment. Individual sounds in a spoken word do not themselves contain the meaning of the word: they come into being and pass away before the word is completed. Meaning is nevertheless communicated in *sphoṭa*, even though its constituent sounds, words or sentences do not coexist at the moment of communication. As a word approaches completion, successive phonemes contribute more intelligibly to its meaning; as a sentence approaches completion, its words become intelligible in sequence. Sāṃkhya, Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta do not accept the doctrine of *sphoṭa*. They hold instead that letters and their sounds fully establish meaning. The author finds a resemblance between the doctrine of *sphoṭa* and Jacques Derrida's theories of deconstruction and dissemination.

The theory of alaṅkāra: Bhāmaha regards *alaṅkāra*, or poetic ornament, in terms of *samāsokti*—condensed or indirect expression that gives pleasure. Daṇḍin and Udbhaṭa also advanced the theory of ornaments. The principal distinction is between ornaments of sound and ornaments of sense. Further distinctions arise through similarity and opposition, reasoning and logic, everyday convention, poetic convention and the apprehension of concealed meaning. Mammaṭa classifies sixty-one ornaments into seven groups: *upamā* (simile or illustrative comparison), *rūpaka* (metaphor), *aprastuta* (indirect praise), *dīpaka* (an ornament uniting or illuminating multiple elements), *vyatireka* (contrast or distinction), *virodha* (opposition), and *samuccaya* (combination).

The theory of aucitya: In the *Aucityavicāracarcā*, Kṣemendra regards propriety or contextual aptness (*aucitya*) as the central element of literature. Where should such aptness be found? In words, sentences, the meaning of the composition, qualities, ornaments, *rasa*, grammatical case, verb, gender, number, adjective, prefix, particle, time, place, lineage, observance, philosophical principle, inner character or disposition, intention, nature, selection of essentials, imagination or genius, condition, thought, name and benediction.

The universe trembles: it is vibration itself. After a poem has been recited, tranquillity spreads—peace everywhere, and peace spreading through the mind.

Poems that praise their authors or attack others offer the blackmailing litterateur opportunities for manipulation. A critic who assesses a work on the basis of evidence can identify this tendency. Casteism and communalism inevitably make their appearance, and it is the critic's responsibility to recognise them. How can literature afflicted by an inferiority complex contribute to human welfare? The critic must recognise that, too. In Maithili literature, where the readership had dwindled almost to zero, one writer reviewed another; personal ego and blackmail had ample scope. These symptoms are still found in the poetry of the dried-up 'mainstream' (!). Attend a few poetry gatherings of that mainstream and the announcer's introductions and applause will expose the prejudices of presenters and writers: poems are written to obtain prizes through blackmail and black-market arrangements. Yet even works awarded the Booker Prize or the Nobel Prize in Literature do not all become timeless. Some are remembered, many are forgotten, and readers thereby pronounce their own judgement.

People read little poetry. Efforts to spread a language such as Sanskrit include conversational camps in which simplified Sanskrit is spoken. Stories and novels are translated from modern languages into Sanskrit, but poetry is largely excluded from the process: if no one reads poetry and a language needs special camps to sustain its spoken use, translating poems into it is treated as a wasteful expenditure of energy. The situation of Maithili has come to resemble this. If village life disappeared today, the number of speakers of the language would become very small; people would speak it only at seminars and literary meetings. One can already feel the need for Maithili pronunciation camps. The plays of caste-bound theatre make it clear that such camps would have to be organised for the dried-up 'mainstream' (!). In such circumstances, what is the need or justification for writing poetry in Maithili? The habit of emphasising that poems are written because there is not enough time makes the situation seem still more alarming.

In these circumstances, neighbourhood happenings, personal ambition, accusations and travel accounts had become the principal subject matter of that dried-up 'mainstream' (!). But why should prose not be used for these purposes? Stories are adapted into plays for performance on stage; what purpose is served by turning prose into poetry? The readers of such hastily composed verse are flattering reviewers and those mighty verse-makers who transform prose into poetry and, through their own prefaces, praise

their own achievements. Who will understand the true value of poetic creation?

If personal, worldly experience does not penetrate deeply, a composition cannot become excellent poetry merely by rhyming. However abstract metaphysical reflection may be, if it does not connect with worldly life, neither unrhymed verse nor a mixture of obscure phrases and ideologies can make it moving. Human beings require food, clothing and shelter; metaphysical reflection comes thereafter. The Buddha asks whether those participating in festivities know that death is inevitable; if they do, how can they go on celebrating? In the same way, contemporary Maithili poets see the linguistic, cultural and economic ground disappearing beneath their feet, and yet close their eyes to that reality. When they then try to force national and international events and ideological positions into verse, or write about the indigenous Dalit community in a spirit of patronising benefaction, their poems lack an edge.

Poetry therefore needs excellence, and it needs a linguistic and cultural foundation. It does not need themes imported merely to perform an act of charity towards it. Nor does it need an imported sensibility offering only a fleeting, charitable glance towards the language, culture and economic foundation vanishing beneath its feet. Good poetry can be written on any subject: on the Buddha's concern for humanity's future; on giving courage to a troubled mind—otherwise people will keep attending the sermons of fraudulent holy men; or on society's linguistic, cultural and economic foundations—otherwise camps will have to be organised to teach Maithili itself.

Images must also communicate. If they do not, an entire atmosphere will have to be prepared in advance for the poet; a stage will have to be arranged for the verse, and training camps organised to explain the poet's vocabulary and ideology. Some poets have indeed been doing this. Poetry ought to contain the gentle rises and falls of Mithila's speech, the rich qualities of its working people, its ways of living and its cultural rigidity, as well as its politics, daily life, social beliefs, economic condition, morality, religion and philosophy. Without these elements poetry becomes one-sided, loses its balance, and turns into something fit merely to be framed and hung on a wall.

Composing poetry is a literary necessity. The day the people of Mithila must be taught their own language in special camps, the very existence of poetry can also be called into question. Poets must remain alert so that this day never comes; and they are alert.

The assertion of superiority in poetry—which may itself be a manifestation of inferiority—must be identified. Identify mediocrity:

stock expressions, the latest breaking news passed off in the name of modernity, writing that has no thought capable of overturning the assumptions of its age. That is why such poetry has little sharpness when it criticises international affairs, Bush and Saddam. Whether it supports or opposes a temple or mosque, or Nandigram and Lalgarh, the edge is similarly missing. The drunken 'humanist,' 'secularist,' 'leftist' and 'rightist' writes with a drowsy consciousness, fills a poem with fashionable expressions, and calls the job finished. How could criticism of America have any bite, or praise of the Left have conviction, when the poet earns a livelihood with the support of the Right?

The absence of struggle, rather than allowing creativity to mature over time, lowers its level. Everyone follows the age; it takes creative courage to go against it. Identify those comfortable, self-serving elements who call others escapists while being unable themselves to venture into depth. A relationship with history can connect one to the historical imagination. Writers weighed down by inferiority and guilt lack the incisiveness needed to overturn the present social order. The materialism of Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and Sāṃkhya–Yoga, their affirmation of external reality and rejection of illusion, household life and the public good, works of art and literature—all these stand in relation to knowledge and insight within the self, which are undivided and involve movement, freedom and creative change.

We cannot change history or literary history. There is also the supposed 'golden age' of Mithila, reconstructed from the memories of its upper and middle classes (!), but such a golden age may have significance only for television and cinema. Liberalism, industrialisation and the achievements and failures of economic development, along with reservations and the expansion of freedoms, dispersed opposition among socially disadvantaged communities while also reducing its intensity, whether in Naxalism, Maoism or Marxism–Leninism. The bourgeoisie benefited. Its political and cultural organisations expanded and sought to reach the proletariat and include women as well. Money and material comfort broke down traditional morality. Companies acquired an independent existence, while families and individuals increasingly ran such enterprises through salaried employees.

Control over nature, observation of human behaviour, grain in return for labour and money in return for labour, employment-guarantee programmes, public-distribution shops, the shrinking of distances between countries in the search for employment, and assaults on the foundations of the family—all belong to a capitalist world economy. Change will not arrive of itself: it must be won through struggle and effort. Independent human feeling guarantees neither a good future nor a bad one. We still have choices, and the evidence of a revival of Maithili

poetry is heartening. Our task is to choose whether to spread sensation or to do the work.

Criticism in the Light of Eastern and Western Critical Theories: Theory and Practice

I have selected some poems by Booch Ji for use as a workshop in the principles and practice of literary criticism.

A Study of Booch Ji's Poems from Marxist, Historical, Structuralist, Magical-Realist, Postmodernist, Feminist and Deconstructionist Perspectives, Together with Indian Aesthetics

Let us go further and see.

Jethī Kareh: In Booch Ji's poem "Jethī Kareh," the poet says that the Kareh River grows turbulent at dawn and rises even when the rainfall has been slight. The danger level is very high; why, then, does it become so restless? At the end, he suggests that it will break its embankments and unleash devastation. This is the poem's ordinary reading.

Now read it structurally. The river becomes turbulent in the morning, from which one may expect that it is not turbulent at other times. It rises in spite of light rain, although it ought not to. The glittering of its water, its circling at bends, and the consequence that it swallows the very heart of inhabited ground form a connected structure. As its sandbanks grow, the poet's patience gives way.

Step away from structuralism and consider historical analysis. For a new age, the poem acquires a new meaning: the danger mark that may have seemed exceptionally high in the poet's time no longer remains so high because of the deposits accumulated within the embankments. For a new generation the poem becomes something different from what it was for the poet. Move now from structuralism to deconstruction. A deconstructionist would say that the structuralist opposition assumes a philosophical polarity. A river rising despite light rainfall, the folly of engineers who try to imprison it in embankments, and the poet's prediction of a catastrophic breach—all these raise the question whether the poet's own polarities are permanent or temporary.

Return again to historicality. In magical-realist literature, a journey into the past brings us to the 1960s, when people were possessed by the obsession with constructing embankments—high, wide barriers that would hold back the river and supposedly bring limitless benefits to humanity. A character living in that historical moment would assign the poem a third meaning. The poet's authority would then disappear, and language would begin its own play. The meaning would be different again for a character

from such literature who lived in the future: that character might not even understand what was meant by the rising danger mark on the river, but would search for the feeling of the poem.

Return to deconstruction and deconstruct further. It may eventually become entangled in its own net. Much will cease to remain, yet much will remain: rain will persist, the river will persist in changed form, and its water will still shimmer in sunlight. Turbulence and rising water will continue.

Svāgat Gān (Welcome Song): At the level of ordinary reading, the poet is welcoming everyone. Yet what can a song of celebration mean amid the pitiful cries of Mithila's uprooted soil? The bee is thirsty; the fruit trees are withering. What can a ceremonial literary gathering achieve at such a time? The poet must carry a stick along with the poem, and a thorny staff along with aesthetic enjoyment.

A note beneath the poem identifies its occasion: the welcome to guests at the Vidyapati Memorial Festival of 1984 in the village of Baidyanathpur, Rosera block, Samastipur district. This was the period when migration from Mithila was beginning. The bridge across the Ganges at Hajipur had been built, yet the model of development seemed to have failed. Faith in great embankments had collapsed. Floods devastated agriculture and farmers; industries based on local crops were absent; and no campaign for education was visible. In those circumstances the poet was entrusted with welcoming a ceremonial assembly.

A reading of "Welcome Song" through the theory of dhvani: By saying that Vidyapati, an embodiment of Śiva, the conqueror of death, has died, the poet brings both meaning and symbol before the reader. Nyāya philosophy opposed the doctrine of *dhvani*, but Booch Ji, a poet from Kariyan, the village of the logician Udayana, is a poet rather than a philosopher. He produces a powerful structure of suggestion: our misfortune has taken root even more deeply; what can a ceremonial assembly alone accomplish? He then asks his listeners to recite poetry but carry a stick on the shoulder: in one hand the source of *rasa*, in the other a thorny staff. Rich in these symbols, the poem advances coherently and welcomes its guests.

From a Marxist standpoint, the poet's task here extends beyond poetic recitation. Affirmation is joined to its negation; the old and the new, development and death, are carefully combined. Had the welcome song detached itself from its circumstances and indulged in empty exclamations of admiration, Marxist criticism would regard it as an inferior poem. The dried-up Maithili mainstream contains an abundance of such songs praising welcome ceremonies and opulence. Booch Ji instead makes the

song part of a dynamic process, thereby turning it into one of Maithili's finest welcome songs.

Beṭī Banalī Pahāṛ (The Daughter Has Become a Mountain): At the level of ordinary reading, the beloved daughter has become a water-pot hanging from her father's neck—a burden. She came as though riding a flying carriage, but, abandoning Hari's Garuḍa, now demands a car. Thirty-five grams of gold have been provided, yet the expenses of the wedding night remain, and the bridegroom's party will arrive from ten villages. Electric bulbs shine everywhere, but darkness occupies the centre. Daśaratha asked for no money, nor did Rāma say anything. History may have offered Kṛṣṇa's love, but what of it? Janaka cries out in distress in the present. Fathers grip their sons by the throat; homes turn into slaughterhouses and villages into markets.

A sociological reading of "The Daughter Has Become a Mountain": This is a poem opposing the dowry system. The cherished daughter who once seemed to arrive in a flying carriage now leaves her father distraught because of the demands of dowry—a system that existed then and continues to exist.

Karuṇ Gīt (Song of Sorrow): At the level of ordinary reading, the sorrowful song of the cuckoo prompts the speaker to behold a flowering grove through tear-filled eyes. At the golden summit of valour comes the easy victory of an ocean of peace. Whenever the speaker embraces something, many crooked thorns pierce. Beauty arrives for only two moments—and departs. Love's honey becomes bitter. The night's lament dissolves into dawn.

A formalist reading of "Song of Sorrow": Consider the act of viewing a flowering forest through tear-filled eyes; the furious image of a burning cremation ground appearing on a bed of erotic love; and the victory of the ocean of peace on the golden summit of valour. The poet makes highly effective use of the unfamiliar possibilities of language, and that is where the poem's poetic quality arises. The abundance of opposing words, their unusual combinations and the figures of speech make this poem distinctive. Images such as a flower piercing like a thorn give it exceptional force from a formalist perspective.

Gāme Mon Paṛaie (It Is the Village I Remember): At the level of ordinary reading, there might not have been even a morsel of bread in the village, and the bathua greens might have lacked salt; nevertheless, in Calcutta it is the village that comes to mind. If the water of the Kareh could irrigate the fields and produce pearls, would the children still be scattered? Is it better to remain a gentleman on the Hooghly or a labouring farmer beside the Kamla? The fields along the Kamla are finer than Eden Gardens.

In Eden Gardens a husband garlands his wife; on the Kamla, a woman of Tirhut searches for *dhaturā* and *ākon* flowers for her Bhola.

A feminist reading of "It Is the Village I Remember": It is a poem about migration. The Tirhut woman searches for flowers for Bhola while Bhola is away in migration. Read existentially, Bhola himself bears responsibility for his situation, for the anxiety of living alone.

Son Dāi: In an ordinary reading, there is neither laughter nor pleasure in Son Dai's life. But why? The children depart, the young people leave, and the old and infirm follow. Why, then, does Son Dai still have faith? The answer comes later: she has forgotten her homeland and lives out her days in exile. As her age advances, how much longer can she remain in Son Dai's home?

A feminist reading of "Son Dai": A theory produced by men within a male-centred society is not necessarily appropriate for women, even if that theory claims to be a principle of poetry. For whose sake does Son Dai, forgetting her homeland, endure exile?

Akāl (Famine): In an ordinary reading of the poem, the poet binds a torch of hunger to the plough and strikes a rhythm on its blade. Drought brings famine and rising prices, so the sky over the burning village becomes red. A dance of death, as in Lanka, begins in India; this time not even Vibhīṣaṇa's house will survive, for its garland of skulls is tied with string. A mother clings to the earth with both arms. The ten-headed Rāvaṇa opens his twenty eyes and shakes his heads.

A reading of "Famine" through the theory of aucitya: This is no ordinary famine but the Great Time of Destruction: hunger is fastened to the plough as a torch, and its blade beats out a rhythm. Such a representation of famine belongs appropriately to the time and place of Mithila; that contextual aptness is the poem's *aucitya*. Rāvaṇa will certainly be uprooted, but Vibhīṣaṇa, too, will not survive.

Tohar Ṭhor (Your Lips): At the level of ordinary reading, the poem joins the lips reddened by betel with the beloved's lips. The beautiful woman applies the lime of speech and decorates her cheeks with red as if stained by catechu. But where is the pipe of love? Dawn's redness resembles her lips; without her, evening is distraught. If a butcher becomes her husband, the speaker will become a broken Rāhu. Nectar is scarce even in heaven; how, then, can the beloved's lips be obtained? The Sakri mill will become great when the speaker learns science from Viśvakarman, and sweetness will emerge from the mill. The beloved's lips resemble a ripe joint of sugarcane. Even in rebirth, the speaker will return as grain and prepared food to reach her. Yet despite all this, the poet says that his purpose has not been revealed through words.

A reading of "Your Lips" through alaṅkāra theory: Applying the lime of speech is an instance of indirect or displaced expression. The cheek reddened like catechu, the relation between betel-stained lips and the beloved's lips, dawn's redness resembling her lips, and her lips compared to a ripe joint of sugarcane are all similes employed by the poet. In the question 'Where is the pipe of love's yearning?' there is an opposition of images. 'Distraught in the middle of the road without you' employs metaphor.

A reading of "Your Lips" through rasa theory: 'You applied the stone-lime of speech / and coloured the cheek with catechu's blood' provides the *vibhāva*, or determining cause. The answering line, 'On seeing it, my heart surged,' presents the *anubhāva*, the manifest consequence.

A reading of "Your Lips" through sphoṭa theory: Although he lives on the soil of Kariyan, Udayana's village, this poet cannot adequately accommodate his verse within the Nyāya rejection of *sphoṭa*. He speaks what remains within his mind and compares the beloved's lips with an elusive thief of hearts. Booch, the poet of Udayana's village, says, 'The description of phonemes is exhausted; the intended meaning is not revealed by words.' Here meaning is communicated not by separate words but by *sphoṭa*, in this poem and throughout the collection. In Maithili, which the author, invoking Yehudi Menuhin, calls the world's most rhythmic and melodious language, such lyricism establishes Booch Ji as its most rhythmic poet after Vidyapati and redefines the possibilities of Maithili poetry.

Some of Maithili's Finest Poetry

In Anjani Kumar Verma 'Dauji's' "Oj ka Bhoj" (A Feast of Vigour), intimacy is described as a mirage; in "Samasyā" (The Problem), he asks how people can become joyful. In "Ātmabal" (Inner Strength), he holds that the blood of Abhimanyu begins to flow only when attachment to one's own life or the lives of others has ended. Balram Sah finds every good thing surprising, and his sleep is broken. Ravi Bhushan Pathak and Vivekanand Jha lay bare a great many matters. In "Ai Ber Chhathi Me" (At Chhath This Year), Ravi Bhushan Pathak offers a new image for the place where the sun rises: 'This time God is rising from behind the Dusadh settlement / … the sky behind the Dusadh settlement was a fierce, clear red.' Vivekanand Jha writes in "Ham" (I): 'I am the oleander fallen from your basket of flowers; / I am the thorn, the useless *kuśa* grass swept here by the fresh waters of the Kosi.'

On Children's Day, Satish Chandra Jha gives musical form to the suffering of little children; a comparable music and rhythm can be found in Rajesh Mohan Jha 'Gunjan' and Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu'. In "Bonihār" (The

Labourer) and "Māṭik Lalkār" (The Challenge of the Earth), Munna Ji connects poetry with contemporary problems.

Amit Mishra, Chandan Kumar Jha, Jagadanand Jha 'Manu', Om Prakash Jha and Ashish Anchinhar all write ghazals in established *bahr*, exposing the ignorance of metre among earlier ghazal writers. Jagadanand Jha 'Manu' writes a *sher*: 'Though the rain may pour fiercely, let the clouds thunder; / the roof has burned, but has my heart not burned too?' Their ghazals possess an intensity and standard far higher than the slack compositions of their older contemporaries Rajendra Vimal and Arvind Thakur, both of whom published collections of free ghazals in 2011.

In "Sūryāst Se Pahine" (Before Sunset), Rajendra Vimal names the metres, but it is difficult to find their presence in the ghazals themselves, however carefully one searches. His practice broadly resembles Siyaram Jha 'Saras's' declaration that he wrote in a particular *bahr* identified as 'Gor-Bi'; Saras Ji, like Rajendra Vimal, wrote only free ghazals. These newer ghazal writers will also present a formidable challenge to the weak free ghazals of other poets associated with the *Jīvan Yug* period. Navin Kumar 'Asha' shows signs of progress. Kishan Karigar has moved from humour towards serious writing and is advancing in both.

For songs, one should read and sing the songs and ghazals of Chandrashekhar Kamat, Jagadish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', Dhirendra Premarshi, Jagadish Prasad Mandal, Shyamal Suman, Prakash Premi, Ramakant Rai 'Rama', Nand Vilas Rai, Bechan Thakur and Ramvilas Sahu. Jay Prakash Mandal writes: 'I registered my name even for the Asian Olympics; / blessed am I that I escaped like this Malleswari.' Satyendra Kumar Jha's short poems are fine: 'Even the cremation ground has no empty fallow land now; / on each patch of earth a body has already burned once— / every new corpse now / burns its ancestors once again along with itself.'

The awakening and natural ease of Pankaj Kumar Jha's verse show poetry's connection with society. For the finest Maithili haiku and tanka, read Vrishesh Chandra Lal. Manoj Kumar Mandal writes of a tree he planted himself that has been overtaken by autumn. The Telugu poems of Anna Varam Devender, the Dogri poems of Champa Sharma, the Bhojpuri poems of Parichay Das and the Odia poems of Ipsita Sarangi address distinct subjects. Devender's poem gives voice to a farmer just before suicide; Champa Sharma dedicates hers to a soldier. Ipsita's short philosophical poem carries densely concentrated imagery.

Mihir Jha's *rubāī* is among the finest in Maithili: 'How shall I hold wine in a pierced heart? / How shall I keep accounts in a distracted mind? / The love that burned was meant for seven births; / how shall I store the answer to

grievances gone by?' Manoj Jha 'Mukti' writes: 'If you must flee at the very beginning, then flee.' Kapileshwar Sahu writes in "Kosi": 'They have made the homestead a pool; / even bamboo cannot sound its depth.' In "Sahās" (Courage), Indrabhushan Kumar writes: 'Suddenly a woman appeared on stage, / dark in appearance ... / fear not if I tell you all; / the audience abused her heartily ... / she did not know how to weave a web of words.' Mridula Pradhan wrote openly in the poems she composed; there is assuredly something astonishing in them. She writes of 'the temptation, through the pen, / to roam among the homes and villages / of the tender young leaves.' Kalinath Thakur's *kuṇḍaliyā* verses on dowry are remarkable. Nikki Priyadarshini writes of the way a woman is seen and treated—

'You are a woman': this constant refrain has not changed. Mohammad Gulhasan writes, 'Such beautiful wheat, uncle, the buffalo has grazed it all; / hurry, hurry, uncle—what an outrage!' The prose poems of Ramesh and Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary are extraordinary. Munni Kamat writes: 'I shall dissolve somewhere; / this pen will stop; / and / words will disappear somewhere.'

The *jhāṛū* compositions of Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar', Maithili's first people's poet, are spontaneous expressions of his poetic feeling. This is why people began calling him the Bhikhari Thakur of Maithili. Consider one such *jhāṛū*: 'Before me there was no government, / nor any constitution of religion. / Without me the world is empty; / the one who destroys me is like an animal.' Ravi Mishra Bharadwaj writes, 'Restlessness began to weep / at my eyes themselves; / people started laughing as they looked at me.' Pramod Rangeele writes, 'Look at the rhythm with which pain speaks. / Look at the nets they cast over the dead.' Rajdev Mandal, author of *Ambara*, described here as the finest Maithili poetry collection of the twenty-first century, writes: 'Like a working bull that strikes with its horns, / he fiercely swears ...'

'... from today, I have become a real man.' Umesh Mandal, Umesh Paswan, Anamika Raj and Sandeep Kumar Safi have a feeling for poetry, a vocabulary of their own and a reality directly lived. Poetry holds its reins in the hands of all four. Whichever direction they fly the kite of their verse in, that will become a direction for Maithili poetry; they have the capacity to carry literature, society and verse as far forward as they wish. Consider these lines from Anamika Raj's "Navkā Bāṭ" (A New Path): 'Labourer or woman! / Both remain objects to be consumed / by feudal lord or capitalist; / and / the one who consumes them / tries to prove his manhood / through a feeble act of crushing them.'

This collection of poetry contains verse, songs, prose poems, ghazals, free ghazals (without *bahr*), devotional ghazals, *rubāī*, *qiṭà*, *hazal*, *nat*, *band*, *qaṣīda*, haiku, tanka and waka, haibun, senryū, *kuṇḍaliyā* (dohā plus rolā),

and *jhāṛū*, among other forms. Whether one considers feminist voices, Dalit discourse, Marxism, humanism or the collective presence of postmodern thought, the collection has achieved a standard in each. It will provide direction for Maithili poetry, and the benchmark it establishes for these forms will open a path to achievements beyond it.

Appendix to the Critical Theory of Poetry

Appendix I

A Critical Theory of the Maithili Ghazal: Towards a Maithili Ghazal Poetics

The ghazal's origins may be traced to Arabic literature, where *arkān* denoted a particular description of a stirring incident. But if the ghazal is the combination of such units, that form is a Persian contribution. From Persian the ghazal passed into Urdu and Hindi, and now into Maithili.

Mayanand Mishra called the Maithili ghazal a *gīt* (song). Here, however, I shall call it a ghazal and use certain terms drawn from Arabic and Persian prosody. The relevant technical vocabulary for Maithili ghazal theory thus belongs to *ʿarūż* (prosody).

Bahr (Metre): Arabic prosody recognises nineteen *buḥūr* (metres). It is unnecessary to memorise so many metres, for *bahr* may be understood by analogy with *thāṭ* and *rāga-rāginī* in Indian music. In place of the nineteen Arabic metres, I shall therefore explain Indian music for Maithili readers below (source: the late Rama Shray Jha 'Ram Rang'). In Devanagari and Mithilakshar, speech is written as pronounced; the short *i* is not an exception in Maithili. The method for counting short and long vowels in Maithili accordingly differs, and it will be explained here. Where a *sher* contains eight *arkān* (four in each of its two *miṣrāʿ*), the metre is called *musamman*; where it contains six (three in each half-line), it is *musaddas*. This also demonstrates once again the scientific basis for writing Maithili case suffixes joined to the words they modify: even when the case suffix is written separately, the metrical feet have to be counted as though it were attached; the suffix is not assigned an independent count.

A metre containing only one *rukn* is a *mufrad bahr*. Where it contains more than one *rukn* (plural: *arkān*), it is a *murakkab bahr*.

Where two *arkān* recur, the form is called *bahr-e-shikasta*.

Miṣrāʿ and sher: In a Maithili ghazal, a two-line couplet describing a particularly stirring event is called a *sher*. One line is a *miṣrāʿ*. Both lines together constitute the *sher*, while each separate line is a *miṣrāʿ*. In the opening couplet (*matlaʿ*), both half-lines have matching *qāfiya*, or rhyme.

Ūlā and sānī: The first *miṣrāʿ* of a *sher* is the *ūlā*; the second is the *sānī*. Two *miṣrāʿs* form the opening couplet, just as two lines form a *dohā*.

Arkān (rukn) and ziḥāf: Eight metrical feet (*arkān*, singular *rukn*) give rise to the nineteen *buḥūr*. These feet are compared here with fundamental *rāgas*, while the metres are likened to their developed forms. Modification of a foot is *ziḥāf*, as in changing *vareṇyam* to *vareṇiyam*.

Taqtīʿ (metrical scansion): A two-line couplet describing a striking event constitutes a *sher*, and a number of such couplets together constitute a ghazal. *Taqtīʿ* is the procedure for dissecting and examining its metre. By scanning the half-line, one determines the *bahr* to which it belongs—the musical *rāga* or *rāginī*, in the analogy employed here.

Matlaʿ (beginning) and maqtaʿ (ending): The first *sher* of a ghazal is its *matlaʿ*; the last its *maqtaʿ*. Both half-lines of the *matlaʿ* rhyme in the same manner, while the poet places a name or pen-name in the *maqtaʿ*. The final signature couplet is sometimes absent, something to be understood in context. The opening *matlaʿ* too, is sometimes missing, though a beginner in ghazal writing should include it.

Qāfiya and radīf: A fixed word or group of words following the rhyme, or associated with the word carrying the rhyme, is called the *radīf*. The rhyming word changes but the *radīf* does not. *Qāfiya* pertains to phonemes or metrical quantities; *radīf* to a word or group of words.

A *sher* containing two rhymes is called *zū-qāfiya*.

Two short syllables may also be substituted for one long syllable.

Just as *qāfiya* operates with syllabic sound and quantity while also involving words, so the *radīf*, conversely, may involve the sounds and quantities contained within a word or phrase. Thus, if the *radīf* in the first line is a group of words, in the second line one of those words may form part of another word: the *radīf* may then be present within a word bearing the *qāfiya*. A *radīf* may also occur between two rhymes. It may range from apparent absence to a single fixed word, a group of words or an entire unchanged sentence. The word bearing the *qāfiya* continues to vary throughout the ghazal.

From the standpoint of Maithili grammar, a ghazal with an unchanged syllabic quantity or unchanged incomplete word may be described as a ghazal without *radīf*, because these are fundamental properties of the *qāfiya*. If instead one looks for an entire unchanged word or phrase, the *radīf* is absent. Classical theory permits this absence without difficulty. At the beginning, however, rather than compose ghazals without *radīf*, the poet should employ a recurring and unchanged word, phrase or sentence—in other words, a clearly identifiable *radīf*.

Bahr and Music

First obtain a keyboard with at least thirty-seven keys.

Divide it into three groups of twelve keys each. Keys numbered 13 and 25 indicate both *sa* and *sā* at the transition between octaves. Each group has five black and seven white keys. The first twelve constitute the lower octave (*mandra saptak*), the next twelve the middle octave (*madhya saptak*), and the twelve at the extreme right the upper octave (*tār saptak*). Mark the keys from 1 to 36 with a marker. The left and right hands will proceed respectively from keys 1 and 13.

A group of twelve keys consists of five black keys and seven white keys.

For the first exercise practise only on the white keys. The first seven white keys are *sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha,* and *ni*. The eighth white key is the higher *sā*, which is also the *sa* of the next group.

With the left hand, play *sa* using the ring finger, *re* with the middle finger, *ga* with the index finger, and *ma* with the thumb. Then pass the ring finger beneath the thumb to play *pa*, play *dha* with the middle finger and *ni* with the index finger, and play the upper *sā* with the thumb. Practise this sequence. With the right hand, begin on the first key of the group of twelve: play *sa* with the thumb, *re* with the index finger, *ga* with the middle finger, and *ma* with the ring finger. Pass the thumb under the ring finger and play *pa* with the thumb, *dha* with the index finger, *ni* with the middle finger, and the upper *sā* with the ring finger. For both hands the upper *sā* is the first white key of the next group of twelve. In an ascending scale it is the *sā* of the first group and, because it is the first key of the second group, also its *sa*.

The second point is that whenever you draw a sound from the keyboard, match it with the sound of your own voice: there should be no difference in pitch, however slight. Third, do not mistake the musical notes *sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha, ni,* and *sā* for letters of Mithilakshar or Devanagari. They indicate only how high or low the notes lie in ascent and descent. Take another sound, such as *ka*, and practise raising and lowering its pitch according to the keyboard notes *sa, re*, and so on.

Of the seven notes, *ṣaḍja* and *pañcama*—that is, *sa* and *pa*—are fixed (*acal*); in a uniform melodic progression their positions are not raised or lowered. *Sa* expresses repose or a resting place, and *pa* expresses exhilaration. The remaining five notes are movable: they admit upward or downward alteration. *Sa* and *pa* have only their natural (*śuddha*) forms. An altered note may be either raised or lowered: a raised note is called *tīvra*, a lowered one *komal*. Except for *ma*, the movable notes are altered downwards. Thus *re, ga, dha,* and *ni* each have two forms, natural and flat

(*komal*); *ma* has the natural and the sharp (*tīvra*) forms. *Re* suggests enthusiasm, *ga* peace, *ma* fear, *dha* sorrow, and *ni* a sense of command. Notes are natural when all seven occupy their assigned positions; they are then written without special signs.

When a natural note is lowered from its assigned position it is called *komal*. There are four such notes, marked by a horizontal sign below: रे॒, ग॒, ध॒, नि॒ (*re, ga, dha, ni*).

When the natural middle note is raised above its position, it is called *tīvra*. The sign is placed above it vertically. There is only one such note: मं (*ma*).

Thus there are seven natural notes—*sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha, ni*—four *komal* notes—रे॒, ग॒, ध॒, नि॒—and one *tīvra* note, मं: twelve notes in all.

It follows that *sa* and *pa* are fixed, while the others may be varied or altered.

Return now to the keyboard. I specified thirty-seven keys because these provide three groups of twelve, together with the thirty-seventh and final key for the upper *sā*.

An octave comprises seven natural and five altered notes: twelve in all.

The twelve white and black keys to the left represent the lower octave, the central twelve the middle octave, and keys 25–36 the upper octave.

Āroh means ascent from low to high—for example, from the lower to the middle octave and from the middle to the upper octave.

A dot is written below the notes of the lower octave, no such mark is needed for the middle octave, and a dot is placed above the notes of the upper octave; thus:

स॒, र॒, ग॒, म॒, प॒, ध॒, न॒ | सा, रे, ग, म, प, ध, नि | सां, रें, गं, मं, पं, धं, निं.

Avroh is descent from the upper to the middle and from the middle to the lower octave.

Vādī svar: the note employed most frequently in a rāga.

Samvādī svar: the note employed most frequently after the *vādī*.

Anuvādī svar: the remaining notes, apart from the *vādī* and *samvādī*.

Varjya svar: a note that is not used in a particular rāga.

Pakaṛ: the characteristic group of notes by which a particular rāga is recognised.

The time of performance is also fixed for different rāgas and rāginīs. *Pūrvāṅga* rāgas are sung or played from noon until midnight, and *uttarāṅga* rāgas from midnight until noon.

The *vādī* of a *pūrvāṅga* rāga is one of *sa, re, ga, ma,* or *pa*; that of an *uttarāṅga* rāga is one of *ma, pa, dha, ni,* or *sa*. A rāga performed at sunrise or sunset is called a *sandhi-prakāśa* rāga.

Classification of Rāgas (*Rāga-jāti*)

A rāga's *jāti* is determined by the number of notes used in its ascending and descending scales.

There are three principal classifications: (1) *sampūrṇa* (seven notes), (2) *ṣāḍava* (six), and (3) *auḍava* (five), their respective standard numbers of notes being seven, six and five.

Now combine these three classifications in pairs.

What is *sampūrṇa–auḍava*? The first term designates the ascending and the second the descending scale. The answer is (7, 5): seven ascending notes and five descending notes. Since *sampūrṇa* has seven and *auḍava* five, their combination is (7, 5). There are accordingly nine combinations of rāga-jāti: (1) *sampūrṇa–sampūrṇa* (7, 7); (2) *sampūrṇa–ṣāḍava* (7, 6); (3) *sampūrṇa–auḍava* (7, 5); (4) *ṣāḍava–sampūrṇa* (6, 7); (5) *ṣāḍava–ṣāḍava* (6, 6); (6) *ṣāḍava–auḍava* (6, 5); (7) *auḍava–sampūrṇa* (5, 7); (8) *auḍava–ṣāḍava* (5, 6); and (9) *auḍava–auḍava* (5, 5).

Thāṭ

A *saptak* contains seven natural, four *komal*, and one *tīvra* notes, twelve in all. A particular group of seven notes from which a rāga originates is called a *thāṭ* or *mel*.

The *thāṭ* is the progenitor of a rāga. It has seven notes and thus belongs to the *sampūrṇa* classification. It contains only an ascending arrangement, never both the natural and altered forms of the same note. The *thāṭs* are named after different rāgas. Their seven notes occur in order, but the *thāṭ* itself is not intended as a melody to be sung.

There are ten *thāṭs*:

1. Āsāvarī — सा रे ग॒ म प ध॒ नि॒.

2. Kalyāṇ — सा रे ग मं प ध नि.

3. Kāfī — सा रे ग॒ म प ध नि॒.

4. Khamāj — सा रे ग म प ध नि̲.

5. Pūrvī — सा रे̲ ग मं प ध̲ नि.

6. Bilāval — सा रे ग म प ध नि.

7. Bhairav — सा रे̲ ग म प ध̲ नि.

8. Bhairavī — सा रे̲ ग̲ म प ध̲ नि̲.

9. Mārwā — सा रे̲ ग मं प ध नि.

10. Toṛī — सा रे̲ ग̲ मं प ध̲ नि.

Varṇa

Varṇa expresses the form and affective character of a rāga. There are four kinds.

1. *Sthāyī*: the recurrence of a single note again and again.

2. *Avarohī*: a succession of notes moving from high to low.

3. *Ārohī*: a succession of notes moving from low to high.

4. *Sañcārī*: the rhythmic combination of the three preceding movements.

Lakṣaṇa-gīt: a composition specifying the *vādī*, *samvādī*, classification, and time of performance so that the rāga's distinctive features become clear.

Sthāyī: the opening section of a song, repeated after every *antarā*.

Antarā: a section sung once after the *sthāyī*.

Alaṅkār/palṭā: the rule-governed performance of sequences of notes, in singing or on an instrument.

Ālāp: an elaborated vocal or instrumental exposition of a group of notes within a particular rāga.

Tān: the rapid vocal or instrumental execution of the notes of a rāga.

A *tān* moves swiftly and is sung or played at double speed.

Now consider *tāl*, the rhythmic cycle. According to musical tempo there are cycles such as *jhaptāl* (ten beats), *tritāl* (sixteen), *ektāl* (twelve), *kaharvā* (eight), and *dādrā* (six).

Kāl is the time required for singing, playing an instrument, or dancing; *laya* is the regular pace followed in performance. A fast *laya* is *drut*, a slow one *vilambit*, and one neither slow nor fast is *madhya laya*.

Mātrā is the unit of a *tāl* and is used to measure *laya*.

When beats are combined into groups within a *tāl*, each group is a *vibhāg*: for instance, *dādrā*, with groups of three beats, has two *vibhāgs*.

The ordered arrangement of the divisions of a *tāl* constitutes *chhand*. The first beat of the first division is the *sam*, marked + or ×; a division without a clap is the *khālī*, marked ○.

The complete formulation indicating the syllables of a *tāl*—its beats, divisions, claps and empty beats—is its *ṭhekā*.

Signs: at the point of clapping, the *tāl* sign and a number; *sam*: + or ×; *khālī*: ○.

S — *avagraha/bikārī*.

— Two *bols* (percussion syllables) within one beat.

— Four *bols* within one beat.

Two *bols* in a beat may be spoken as *dhā-ge*; four as *dhā-ge-ti-ṭa*.

An Introduction to Tāls

Kaharvā Tāl

Four beats, a single division, and *sam* on the first beat.

Dhā ginā tinak dhin.

Tīntāl / Tritāl

Sixteen beats in four divisions of four beats each. Claps fall on beats 1, 5 and 13; the *khālī* falls on beat 9.

Dhā dhin dhin dhin.

Dhā dhin dhin dhā.

Dhā tin tin tā.

Tā dhin dhin dhā.

Jhaptāl

Ten beats in four divisions of 2, 3, 2 and 3 beats respectively.

Sam is on beat 1, *khālī* on beat 6, and claps on beats 3 and 8.

Dhī nā.

Dhī dhī nā.

Tī nā.

Dhī dhī nā.

Rūpak Tāl

Seven beats in divisions of 3, 2 and 2.

The first division is empty (*khālī*); the following two are marked by claps.

The first beat is both *sam* and *khālī*; claps occur on beats 4 and 6.

Dhī dhā trak.

Dhī dhī.

Dhā trak.

Counting Short and Long Syllables

There are two kinds of metre: *mātrik* (quantitative) and *vārṇik* (syllabic). The Vedas employ *vārṇik* metres.

Consider *vārṇik* metre, in which syllables alone are counted. A consonant bearing a *halant* does not receive an independent count. A letter bearing a vowel sign such as *e* or *u* is counted as one, as is a conjunct consonant. The letters from *a* through *ha* are likewise counted singly. No syllable is given a double count in this system. Remember three principal rules:

(1) A letter with *halant*: 0; (2) a conjunct letter: 1; (3) each letter from *a* to *ha*: 1.

Now examine the first example:

"ई अरदराक मेघ नहि मानत रहत बरसि के" (*Ī ardarāk megh nahi mānat rahat barasi ke*) = 1 + 5 + 2 + 2 + 3 + 3 + 3 + 1 = 20 syllabic units (*mātrās*).

The second example is *paścāt* (पश्चात्) = 2 units. Now consider a third example.

Āb (आब) = 2 units; a fourth example is *skripṭ* (स्क्रिप्ट) = 2 units.

A composition governed by metre is called *padya*, or verse; otherwise it is *gadya*, prose. A *chhand* is a composition that gives pleasure. Yet this does not mean that modern new poetry must be classified as prose. Even the Vedic Sāvitrī–Gāyatrī mantra is reckoned in the Gāyatrī metre by a flexible, generous rule: when a line lacks the required number of syllables,

one or two may be added within each *pāda*. The conjuncts involving *ya* and *va* may be separated by inserting *i* and *u* respectively. Thus *vareṇyam* becomes *vareṇiyam*.

Svah (स्वः) becomes *suvah* (सुवः).

Apart from Tamil, the scripts of southern India and those of northern, western and eastern India, including Devanagari, possess broadly similar vowel inventories and the consonant groups *ka, ca, ṭa, ta,* and *pa*, with a correspondence between writing and pronunciation. The short *i* in Devanagari is an exception: written before a consonant, it is pronounced after it. In Maithili, however, even this exception does not arise in the same way: *achhi* (अछि) is pronounced with the short *i* as *a–i–chha*; compare *rāti–rāit* (राति–राइत). Consider another example. *Sandhi*, or euphonic combination, is characteristic of Sanskrit; but does it not occur in English? "I'm going towards the end" is spoken with *I'm* in place of "I am going towards the end." Pāṇini established rules of *sandhi* on the basis of phonetics. English spelling does not ordinarily represent every spoken combination in this way, although *I'm* is written phonetically and the combination is used in speech. In Maithili, too, case endings are, wherever possible, both written and pronounced together with the words to which they belong.

There are two types of metre: quantitative (*mātrā chhand*) and syllabic (*varṇa chhand*).

Syllabic metres (*varṇa-vṛtta*) are used in the Vedas.

The principal Vedic metres are seven:

Gāyatrī, Uṣṇik, Anuṣṭubh, Bṛhatī, Paṅkti, Triṣṭubh and Jagatī. The other forms are varieties of these, designated *atichhand* and *vichhand*. Metres are identified here through syllable counts. If the required number of syllables is not attained, one or two may be added to each *pāda*. Conjuncts with *ya* or *va* may be separated by inserting *i* or *u* respectively. For example:

Vareṇyam = vareṇiyam.

Svah = suvah.

The vowels resulting from *guṇa* and *vṛddhi* may also be separated to complete the syllable count.

E = a + i; *o = a + u*; *ai = a/ā + e*; *au = a/ā + o*.

Consider the *guru* (heavy) and *laghu* (light) syllables used in prosody.

Among thirteen vowel letters, *a, i, u, ṛ,* and *ḷ* are five short vowels; *ā, ī, ū, ṝ, e, ai, o,* and *au* are eight long vowels.

When a vowel is joined to a consonant it produces a vowel-bearing syllabic character, a *guṇitākṣar*.

Ka is formed from *k* + *a*: क् + अ = क.

Kā is formed from *k* + *ā*: क् + आ = का.

A single vowel or a single consonant bearing a vowel constitutes one *akṣara*, or syllable. A bare consonant is not counted as a syllable. Thus *avāk* (अवाक्) contains two: *a* and *vā*.

"There is an exception for *mha* (म्ह) and *nha* (न्ह)." But this is not a rule for Maithili. It is a rule found in Hindi, and a few Maithili authors have followed Hindi in writing *nahiyo* (नहियो). In Maithili the preceding short vowel in combinations such as *mha* and *nha* is generally pronounced as long. Ask a child to pronounce *chhani* (छनि) and *chhanhi* (छन्हि). The *chha* of *chhani* is short, but in *chhanhi* it is pronounced long. Likewise the *ji* in *jimhar* (जिम्हर) is long in verse. A poet may occasionally take such a vowel as short in a particular line, which may be accepted as an exception in that line; but it is unnecessary to admit an exception into the rule merely by imitating Hindi. Those familiar with Maithili singing will understand this still better. Verse is first read and then sung. Thus, in singing "*hamar svar*" ("our voice"), the final *ra* of *hamar* may be lengthened, although it belongs to a different word, because the metrical reckoning proceeds through the line of verse. If the opening letter of the next line is conjunct and the last syllable of the preceding line is short, however, the short syllable will not be lengthened on that account: counting ends at the end of the line.

A long vowel is different from *bikārī* (ऽ, *avagraha* in Sanskrit, *japhalā* in Bengali). Even four such marks do not make a vowel long. Consider the children's song "*megh* ऽ ऽ ऽ ऽ ऽ ऽ *ra*": these remain short syllables. At the end of a metrical line a short syllable may, when necessary, be treated as long, and a long syllable as short.

The weight (*vazn*) of a line (*miṣrā*) in a ghazal, or of its words, can be established in three ways: by simply counting syllables in a simple syllabic metre; by examining both syllables and the sequence of short and long quantities in *vārṇik* metre; or by examining the sequence of short and

long quantities in *mātrik* metre. Anyone with even a little knowledge of singing understands that the number of words in one line of a ghazal may differ from that in another, while the metrical weight is the same when measured by any one of these three methods. A free ghazal (*āzād ghazal*) is without *bahr*, however, so equal weight in its lines or words does not arise. In ghazals written by these three metrical methods the lines have equal weight. Much depends on the capacities of both poet and singer. For the ghazal writer, the *vārṇik* system is the most difficult, *mātrik* somewhat easier, and simple syllable counting easiest. For the singer the order is reversed: *vārṇik* is easiest, *mātrik* more difficult, simple syllabic metre harder still, and the free ghazal, without *bahr*, most difficult of all.

1. Every short vowel and every vowel-bearing character containing a short vowel is *laghu*, or light. It is marked with U above it.

2. Every long vowel and every vowel-bearing character containing a long vowel is *guru*, or heavy. Its sign is a short horizontal stroke (—) written above it.

3. Every syllable containing *anusvāra* or *visarga* is regarded as *guru*.

4. A syllable followed by a conjunct consonant or a bare consonant is counted as *guru*. For example, *ac* (अच्) and *satya* (सत्य): both *a* and *sa* are heavy.

Just as syllabic metre was used in the Vedas, a developed analysis of accent and pitch also existed in that period. Broadly speaking, it is divided into (1) *udātta*, (2) *udāttatara*, (3) *anudātta*, (4) *anudāttatara*, (5) *svarita*, (6) *anudāttānurakta-svarita*, and (7) *pracaya*. The last is described as a *śruti* or unstruck sound (*anāhata nāda*) arising without the impact of one object against another; the others are struck sounds (*āhata nāda*) produced through contact.

1. *Udātta*: a vowel such as *a* pronounced in the upper part of its place of articulation, such as the throat. It carries no mark.

2. *Udāttatara*: pronounced from a still higher position of the throat or other place of articulation.

3. *Anudātta*: pronounced from the lower part of the throat or corresponding place of articulation. An oblique sign is placed below it.

4. *Anudāttatara*: pronounced from a position very much lower in the throat or other place of articulation.

5. *Svarita*: a sound containing *anudātta* in part and *udātta* in part; a vertical stroke is written above it.

6. *Anudāttānurakta-svarita*: a form in which *udātta*, *svarita*, or both follow. It is of three kinds.

7. *Pracaya*: where *anudātta* follows *svarita*, the unstruck sound and the extension or *tān* of *pracaya* arise.

1. The *Pūrvārcika* contains, in sequence, hymns addressed to Agni, Indra, and Soma Pavamāna. There follow the Āraṇyaka section and the Mahānāmnī Ārcika. The Āgneya, Aindra, and Pāvamāna sections are also called *grāmageya-gāna*, while the remainder of the *Pūrvārcika* is known as *āraṇyaka-gāna*. Together these are termed *prakṛti-gāna*.

2. The *Uttarārcika* is also called *vikṛti* or *uttara-gāna*. Mantras selected from *grāmageya-gāna* and *āraṇyaka-gāna* form, respectively, the *ūha-gāna* and *ūhya-gāna*. Each form of singing is divided into sections named *daśarātra, saṃvatsara, ekāha, ahīna, prāyaścitta,* and *kṣudra*. Remembering the melodic patterns of the *Pūrvārcika* mantras, these patterns are used in the *Uttarārcika* for groups of two, three, or four mantras, called *dvika, trika,* and *catuṣṭaka*. In most such groups the first mantra derives from the *Pūrvārcika*, and the entire hymn is sung to its melodic pattern.

In the *Uttarārcika*, the *ūha* and *ūhya* performances each recite a melodic pattern three times in three ways. In Vedic ritual, the *prastāva* is sung by the *prastotṛ*; the *udgītha* by the *udgātṛ*; the *pratihāra* by the *pratihartṛ*; the *upadrava* again by the *udgātṛ*; and the *nidhana* by all three together. Before the *prastāva*, all three chant the *hiṅkāra* ("hiṃ, huṃ, haṃ"), and before the *udgītha* the *udgātṛ* chants *oṃ*. These constitute the five *bhaktis* or sections.

Hand gestures: (1) 1—the thumb, counted as the first finger, one barley-grain's width away; (2) 2—the thumb touching the first finger; (3) 3—the thumb touching the middle finger; (4) 4—the thumb touching the fourth finger; (5) 5—the thumb touching the fifth finger; (6) 11—the sixth, *kruṣṭa*, with the thumb two barley-grains away from the first finger; (7) 6—the seventh, *atisvara*, in the Sāmaveda; (8) 7—*abhigīta*, in the Ṛgveda.

Grāmageya-gāna was sung in villages and public places.

Āraṇyaka-geya-gāna was sung in forests and sacred places.

Ūha-gāna was sung at Soma sacrifices and particular religious occasions, using this method in the *grāmageya-gāna* associated with the *Pūrvārcika*. *Ūhya-gāna*, or esoteric song, is sung in forests and sacred places and is related to the Āraṇyaka singing of the *Pūrvārcika*. The *Nāradīya Śikṣā* specifies for *sāma-gāna*: seven notes, three *grāmas*, twenty-one *mūrchanās*, and forty-nine *tāns*.

The seven notes are *sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha,* and *ni*; the three *grāmas* are middle, low and high. Seven times three gives twenty-one *mūrchanās*; seven notes combined with seven notes yield forty-nine *tāns*.

Each Ṛgvedic mantra becomes equivalent to three through two Sāman chants (*parka*) attributed to Gautama and one to Kāśyapa. Macdonell regards Indrāgnī, Mitrāvaruṇau, Indrāviṣṇū, and Agnīṣomau as pairs of deities; but the paired deity is here treated as a matter of reversal of qualifying terms.

Methods of Vedic Recitation

1. *Saṃhitā-pāṭha*: recitation in the continuous, original form.

"Agnim īḷe purohitaṃ yajñasya devam ṛtvijam, hotāraṃ ratnadhātamam" (अग्निमीळे पुरोहितं यज्ञस्य देवमृत्विजम। होतारंरत्न धातमम्।).

2. *Pada-pāṭha*: reading each word separately.

3. *Krama-pāṭha*: reading the first and second words, then the second and third, then the third and fourth, and so on.

4. *Jaṭā-pāṭha*: if the three words are A, B and C, the sequence is AB, BA, AB, BC, CB, BC. 5. *Ghana-pāṭha*: using the same example, AB, BA, ABC, CBA, ABC. Further forms are 6. *Mālā*, 7. *Śikhā*, 8. *Rekhā*, 9. *Dhvaja*, 10. *Daṇḍa*, and 11. *Ratha*. The last eight are called the *aṣṭavikṛtis*.

There are also six *sāma-vikāras*, through which material may be shortened or lengthened for singing: (1) *vikāra*, changing *agne* to *ognāya*; (2) *viśleṣaṇa*, separating a word or phrase; (3) *vikarṣaṇa*, stretching a vowel or giving it additional duration; (4) *abhyāsa*, repeating an expression; (5) *virāma*, breaking a word by introducing a pause (*yati*) in its middle; and (6) *stobha*, inserting a vocable suitable for melodic elaboration. The Kauthuma school adds "hāu" and "rāi"; the Rāṇāyanīya school adds "hāvu" and "rāyi".

The Vedas do not use *mātrik* metres; they employ *varṇa-vṛtta*, counted by *pāda* or quarter-line. The principal metre is Gāyatrī, most frequently used in the Vedas, followed by Triṣṭubh and Jagatī.

1. *Gāyatrī*: three *pādas* of eight syllables each, with a pause after the second; alternatively, six syllables in each of four divisions.

2. *Triṣṭubh*: four *pādas* of eleven syllables each.

3. *Jagatī*: four *pādas* of twelve syllables each.

4. *Uṣṇik*: two *pādas* of eight syllables each, followed by one of twelve.

5. *Anuṣṭubh*: four *pādas* of eight syllables each; it is more common in Sanskrit literature than in the Vedas.

6. *Bṛhatī*: two *pādas* of eight, followed by two of twelve and eight units respectively, described here as *mātrās*.

7. *Paṅkti*: five *pādas* of eight syllables, with a pause after the first two.

If the count is deficient, one or two syllables may be added or omitted in the following ways.

(a) *Vareṇyam* becomes *vareṇiyam*; *svah* becomes *suvah*.

(b) The combinations formed by *guṇa* and *vṛddhi sandhi* may be separated.

E = a + i.

O = a + u.

Ai = a/ā + e.

Au = a/ā + o.

If the requisite number is still not attained, the resulting varieties receive names such as *virāṭ*.

Thus, for Gāyatrī (24 syllables): *Virāṭ* (22), *Nicṛt* (23), *Śuddhā* (24), *Bhurik* (25), and *Svarāṭ* (26).

"Oṃ bhūr bhuvaḥ svaḥ. Tat savitur vareṇyaṃ. Bhargo devasya dhīmahi. Dhiyo yo naḥ pracodayāt." (ॐ भूर्भुवस्वः। तत् सवितुर्वरेण्यं। भर्गो देवस्य धीमहि। धियो यो नः प्रचोदयात्।)

Vedic seers call both themselves and the gods poets. The whole body of Vedic literature is the verbal embodiment of this poetic consciousness. In it, spiritual consciousness rises into the realm of divinity and takes form in language pertaining to the material world. Even in that period, however, a group recitation of hymns could be likened to the croaking of frogs—as in the Atharvaveda—suggesting an acceptance of dissenting voices in song.

Except for Devanagari, the scripts of northern Indian languages, those of Nepal, and those of southern languages apart from Tamil all use, in alphabetic form, the vowels and the consonant groups *ka, ca, ṭa, ta,* and *pa*, together with *ya, ra, la, va, śa, sa,* and *ha*. Sanskrit also has a special character for a sound here represented as *gvaṅ* (ग्वाङ): it is not pronounced in the Chāndogya tradition, but occurs prominently in Vājasaneyī pronunciation; compare the forms "sabhūmi" and "sabhūmīgvaṅ" in the passage. It can be short or long. Mithilakshar likewise employs at least six

distinct letters for *siddhir astu*. Vedic Sanskrit uses *udātta, anudātta,* and *svarita* marks (क॑, क॒, क॓), while Marathi also uses ळ and the half-र sign.

Maithili uses ऽ, *bikārī* or *avagraha*, as Sanskrit does. Today typographical convenience sometimes produces द' in place of दऽ; this is evidence of a technical deficiency in the font. After the long *ā* vowel sign there is no need for *bikārī*.

Just as the Persian alphabet is called *alif, be, se* and the Roman alphabet *A, B, C*, the overall structure of the alphabet is much the same across Indian languages despite differences in script.

The alphabet comprises two kinds of sound, vowels and consonants. There are sixty-four letters: twenty-two vowels and forty-two consonants.

Consider the vowels first. A vowel is a sound whose pronunciation does not depend on the pronunciation of any other letter.

Vowels are of three kinds: *hrasva* (short), *dīrgha* (long), and *pluta* (prolonged). A short vowel occupies one unit of time, a long vowel two, and a prolonged vowel three.

The basic vowels are *a, i, u, ṛ,* and *ḷ*.

Grammarians before Pāṇini called them *samānākṣara*.

The long compound vowels are *e, ai, o,* and *au*.

Grammarians before Pāṇini called these *sandhyakṣara*.

Ḷ has no long form, and the compound vowels have no short forms.

The short, long (*ā, ī, ū, ṝ*), and prolonged (*ā3, ī3, ū3, ṝ3*) forms of *a, i, u,* and *ṛ* together produce twelve vowels. The short and prolonged forms of *ḷ* (the latter shown as ऌ३) add two. The four long compound vowels *e, ai, o,* and *au* also have prolonged forms (*e3, ai3, o3, au3*), adding eight: twenty-two vowels altogether.

All twenty-two have three forms of Vedic accent: *udātta, anudātta,* and *svarita*.

A vowel such as *a* articulated from a higher place, for instance the palate, has the property of *udātta* and is so called. One articulated from a lower position is *anudātta*. When the first part of a vowel is pronounced with *udātta* and the second with *anudātta*, it is *svarita*.

Vowels are further divided into nasalised (*sānunāsik*, as in अँ) and non-nasalised (*niranunāsik*, as in अ).

"*Dattena nirvṛttaḥ kūpo dāttaḥ*": a well built by a man named Datta on the northern bank of the Vipāṭ–Vyās is called *dātta*. Because it takes the affix *añ*, *dātta* has initial *udātta* accent; had it taken the affix *aṇ*, the accent would have been on the ending by virtue of the affix. The form is the same, but the accent differs. This establishes that ordinary members of the agricultural community too pronounced words with distinctions of accent.

Svarita may also be understood in another way, as a repetition of the final vowel at a higher pitch.

Turn now to consonants.

There are forty-two consonants.

क् ख् ग् घ् ङ् — *k, kh, g, gh, ṅ.*

च् छ् ज् झ् ञ् — *c, ch, j, jh, ñ.*

ट् ठ् ड् ढ् ण् — *ṭ, ṭh, ḍ, ḍh, ṇ.*

त् थ् द् ध् न् — *t, th, d, dh, n.*

प् फ् ब् भ् म् — *p, ph, b, bh, m.*

य् र् ल् व् — *y, r, l, v.*

श् ष् स् — *ś, ṣ, s.*

ह् — *h.*

Ya, va, and *la* can also be nasalised (यँ, वँ, लँ), as distinct from their non-nasalised forms.

Besides these, there are two further consonantal signs: *anusvāra* and *visarjanīya*, or *visarga*.

Both occur after vowels.

The *visarjanīya* is not an original letter but an alteration of *s* or *r*. It has two varieties, distinguished in sound and form: *jihvāmūlīya* and *upadhmānīya*. The former occurs only before *ka* and *kha*, the latter only before *pa* and *pha*.

Anusvāra, visarjanīya, jihvāmūlīya, and *upadhmānīya* are called *ayogavāha*.

In addition to these, there are four more sounds called *yama*.

कुँ खुँ गुँ घुँ (*kuṃ, khuṃ, guṃ, ghuṃ*), as in the examples पलिक् क्नी, चख ख्नुतः, अग् ग्निः, घ् घ्नन्ति.

A *yama* is the intermediate sound resembling an earlier consonant when the fifth consonant of a group follows it.

The *yamas*, too, are *ayogavāha*.

A, ā, the *ka* group, *ha* (when not conjunct), and *visarjanīya* are articulated in the throat.

I, ī, the *ca* group, *ya,* and *śa* are articulated at the palate.

Ṛ, ṝ, the *ṭa* group, *ra,* and *ṣa* are articulated with the tongue raised towards the roof of the mouth.

Ḷ, the *ta* group, *la,* and *sa* are articulated at the teeth.

U, ū, the *pa* group, and *upadhmānīya* are articulated at the lips.

Va is articulated with the lower lip assisted by the upper teeth.

E and *ai* are articulated at the throat and palate.

O and *au* are articulated at the throat and lips.

In pronouncing *ya, ra, la,* and *va*, the front and other parts of the tongue do not make complete contact with the palate or corresponding point, as with other consonants. Nor is there the friction at these points found in *śa, ṣa, sa,* and *ha*.

The letters from *ka* through *ma* are stops, or plosives, because the tongue temporarily interrupts and then releases the airflow. The consonants from *ra* to *va* are approximants (*antaḥstha*), and those from *ṣa* to *ha* are fricatives.

The fifth letter of every consonant group is nasal, because, while its other places of articulation remain similar, it is also articulated through the nose: the outgoing air passes through both mouth and nostrils.

Anusvāra and *yama* are articulated only nasally and are therefore called *nāsikya*: the mouth passage is closed and air escapes through the nose. *Anusvāra* should not be pronounced as *n* or *m*.

When we wish to speak, intention stimulates the digestive fire (*jaṭharāgni*). Air near the navel rises forcefully towards the head; after its flow is checked by the front or another part of the tongue and it rubs against the palate or other part of the mouth, speech sounds are generated. Vibration makes the air resonant (*nādavān*). If the sound reaches the

mouth resonating, it is voiced (*ghoṣavān*); if it reaches the breath without resonance, it is unvoiced (*aghoṣavān*).

Sounds of the nature of breath are *aghoṣa* (unvoiced), while those of the nature of resonance are *ghoṣavān* (voiced). Sounds produced with relatively little breath are *alpaprāṇa* (unaspirated), and those requiring a greater release of breath are *mahāprāṇa* (aspirated).

In each of the *ka, ca, ṭa, ta,* and *pa* groups, the first, third, and fifth consonants are *alpaprāṇa*, while the second and fourth are *mahāprāṇa*. In those groups the first two consonants are unvoiced, and the third, fourth and fifth are voiced. *Ya, ra, la,* and *va* are unaspirated and voiced; *śa, ṣa,* and *sa* are aspirated and unvoiced; *ha* is aspirated and voiced. Vowels are unaspirated and can bear *udātta, anudātta,* or *svarita* accent.

Now let us write the Maithili ghazal. There are arguments in favour of poetry, anti-poetry, prose poetry and verse alike. The Maithili ghazal, therefore, must necessarily be composed in a *bahr* (metre), whether in simple syllabic, syllabic or quantitative metre. Just as there are the *soraṭhā* and the *caupāī*, so there is the ghazal. In Urdu an attempt was made at an unmetrical, free ghazal under the name *āzād ghazal*. Needless to say, it did not gain acceptance. Since AD 539, metrical ghazals have been written in Arabic, and they continue to be written today. Persian and Urdu ghazals, too, are not composed without metre. A ghazal can even make fun of God; in that respect it is liberal. But when it comes to metre it is highly uncompromising. This rigour has not diminished the ghazal in Arabic, Urdu or Persian. Correspondence of quantity and an easy flow are customary features of the ghazal and constitute its distinguishing character; otherwise it would become a *nazm*.

A Course in Language Editing in Maithili

2.1. Instructions on Pronunciation (the bold forms are acceptable)

In articulating the dental न (*na*), the tongue touches the teeth, as in नाम (*nām*); in articulating ण (*ṇa*), it touches the roof of the mouth, as in गणेश (*Gaṇeś*). Failure to make this contact constitutes a fault of pronunciation. In palatal श (*śa*) the tongue meets the palate; for ष (*ṣa*) it meets the roof of the mouth, and for dental स (*sa*) it meets the teeth. Say निशाँ, सभ and शोषण and observe the difference. In Maithili, ष is also pronounced like ख (*kha*), as in Vedic Sanskrit: for example, in वर्षा and दोष. At many points य is pronounced like ज, and ण like ड़: thus संयोग and गणेश may be

pronounced संजोग and गड़ेस. In Maithili, व may likewise be pronounced ब, श as स, and य as ज.

Likewise, the short इ is often articulated before the consonant in Maithili, for it is written before the consonant both in Devanagari and in Mithilākṣara and, according to this rule, should be pronounced before it as well. The defective pronunciation found in Hindi, where the sign is written first but sounded later, has, through defects of education, led us to pronounce it incorrectly.

अछि — अइछ /ऐछ (pronunciation).

छथि — छइथ /छैथ (pronunciation).

पहुँचि — पहुँइच (pronunciation).

There are vowel signs for अ, आ, इ, ई, ए, ऐ, ओ, औ, अं, अः and ऋ. Yet ई, ऐ, ओ, औ, अं, अः and ऋ are often wrongly employed and pronounced as though they were conjunct letters: for instance, ऋ is pronounced *rī*. Similarly, using देखिऔ for देखियौ is inappropriate; conversely, देखियै is inappropriate for देखिऐ. When अ is added to the consonants from क् through ह्, the forms क through ह result. A tendency has nevertheless grown to pronounce a final consonant with a *halant*. Thus, when I pronounce the final ज् in मनोज, I can still hear older speakers pronounce मनोजऽ; in fact they are sounding ज with its inherent अ.

The conjunct ज्ञ comprises ज् and ञ, but is incorrectly pronounced *gya*. Likewise, क्ष comprises क् and ष but is pronounced *cha*. श्र, as in श्रमिक, is the conjunct श् + र; स्र, as in मिस्र, is स् + र. त्र is त् + र.

Audio recordings of pronunciation are available in the Videha archive at http://www.videha.co.in/. Write कैँ, सँ and पर attached to the preceding word, but write तँ and कऽ separately. When two instances of सँ occur in a construction, attach the first and separate the second. Attach टा to a numeral, but separate it elsewhere: thus छहटा, but सभ टा. For the ordinal

spellings, the source gives the contrast "६अमसातम" /"छठमसातम" and rejects the second form. Use बला in घरबला, but वाली in घरवाली.

रहए — रहै; but सकैए (pronounced सकै-ए).

Sometimes, however, रहए and रहै also differ in meaning, as in: "से कम्मो जगहमे पार्किंग करबाक अभ्यास रहै ओकरा।" On inquiry it emerged that the driver, named Dhundhun, worked at the parking facility in Connaught Place: "पुछलापर पता लागल जे ढुनढुन नाम्ना ई ड्राइवर कनाट प्लेसक पार्किंगमे काज करैत रहए।"

The distinction is similar in छलै and छलए. The latter may also be pronounced छल-ए.

संयोगने — pronounced संजोगने.

कैं /कऽ.

केर /क: do not use केर in prose; it may be used in verse.

क, as in रामक: रामक, also pronounced राम के or राम कऽ.

सँ — pronounced सऽ.

Candrabindu and *anusvāra*: in the latter, articulation extends to the throat; this is not so with *candrabindu*, which can also carry a slight *e*-like sound. Thus रामसँ may be pronounced राम सऽ, and रामकैं as राम कऽ or राम के.

कैं, as in रामकैं, corresponds to Hindi को (राम को): राम को = रामकैं.

क, as in रामक, corresponds to Hindi का (राम का): राम का = रामक.

कऽ, as in जा कऽ, corresponds to Hindi कर (जा कर): जा कर = जा कऽ.

सँ corresponds to Hindi से (राम से): राम से = रामसँ.

The use of these four forms is undesirable: सऽ, तऽ, त and केर (in prose).

के can be used in another sense, as in के कहलक? ("Who said it?"). Its use in place of the case ending क is undesirable.

नञि, नहि, नै, नइ, नँइ, नइँ and नइं: the form given here for pronunciation and writing is नै.

Use त्व instead of त्त्व, as in महत्वपूर्ण rather than महत्त्वपूर्ण. A conjunct of three letters is appropriate only where the meaning would otherwise change. Write सम्पति, pronounced स-म्-प-इ-त, rather than सम्पत्ति, because accurate pronunciation of the latter is not easy. But write सर्वोत्तम, not सर्वोतम.

राष्ट्रिय (not राष्ट्रीय); सकैए /सकै (difference in meaning); पोछैले /पोछैलेल / पोछएलेल.

पोछैए /पोछए (difference in meaning); पोछए /पोछैओ लोकनि (written separately, without an added *bikārī* sign).

ओइ /ओहि; ओहिले /ओहिलेल /ओही लऽ; जएबेँ /बैसबेँ; पँचभइयाँ.

देखियौक (not देखिऔक); similarly, the inappropriate deployment of short and long vowel signs in this context.

जकाँ /जेकाँ; तँइ /तैँ; होएत /हएत; नञि /नहि /नँइ /नइँ /नै.

सौँसे /सौंसे; बड़ /बड़ी (झोराओल); गाए (not गाइ), but गाइक दूध (not गाएक दूध).

रहलेँ /पहिरतैँ; हमहीं /अहीं; सब /सभ; सबहक /सभहक.

धरि — तक ("up to"); गप — बात ("talk"); बूझब — समझब ("to understand"); बुझलौं /समझलौं /बुझलहुँ /समझलहुँ.

हमरा आर — हम सभ; आकि /आकि; सकैछ /करैछ (unnecessary in prose).

होइन /होनि; जाइन् (not जानि, as in देल जाइन्), but जानि-बूझि, where the meaning is different.

पइठ /जाइठ; आउ /जाउ /आऊ /जाऊ.

Write मे, कैँ, सँ and पर attached to the preceding word; write तँ, कऽ, धऽ and दऽ separately. When two or more case endings occur together, attach only the first, as in ऐमेसँ.

एकटा, दूटा; but कएटा.

Use *bikārī* at the end of a word, not unnecessarily in its middle. Do not place it after a final आ or अ, as in the examples दिअ and आ /दिय', आ', आनै.

Substituting an apostrophe for *bikārī* is incorrect and merely reveals a technical limitation of the font. The corresponding Sanskrit sign, ऽ, is called *avagraha*, and in spelling or pronunciation it can disappear (it does disappear in pronunciation). In English, however, the apostrophe also marks the possessive case; in French it occurs within words, as in *raison d'être*, pronounced "raison d'être." An apostrophe does not create a gap: it joins. For this reason also, its use instead of *bikārī* is technically inappropriate.

अइमे /एहिमे /ऐमे; जइमे /जाहिमे; एखन /अखन /अइखन; कैँ (not के); मे (without *anusvāra*).

भऽ; मे; दऽ; तँ (not तऽ or त); सँ (not सऽ or स); गाछतर; गाछलग; साँझखन.

जो (as in जो, "go," and करै जो, "do"); तै /तइ, as in तै दुआरे /तइमे /तइले.

जै /जइ, as in जै कारण /जइसँ /जइले.

ऐ /अइ, as in ऐ कारण /ऐसँ /अइले; but note the special use in "लालति कतेक दिनसँ कहैत रहैत अइ."

लै /लइ, as in लैसँ /लइले /लै दुआरे; लहँ /लौं.

गेलौं /लेलौं /लेलँह /गेलहुँ /लेलहुँ /लेलँ; जइ /जाहि /जै.

जहि ठाम /जाहि ठाम /जइ ठाम /जै ठाम; एहि /अहि.

अइ (acceptable at the end of a sentence) /ऐ; अइछ /अछि /ऐछ.

तइ /तहि /तै /ताहि; ओहि /ओइ; सीखि /सीख; जीवि /जीवी /जीब.

भलेहीं /भलहिं; तैं /तँइ /तँए; जाएब /जएब; लइ /लै; छइ /छै.

नहि /नै /नइ; गइ /गै; छनि /छन्हि …

When a case ending is attached to समए, the form becomes समै, as in समै पर. When standing alone, the form is हृदए; with a case ending, it becomes हृदे, as in हृदे सँ and हृदेमे.

जइ /जाहि /जै; जहि ठाम /जाहि ठाम /जइ ठाम /जै ठाम.

एहि /अहि /अइ /ऐ; अइछ /अछि /ऐछ; तइ /तहि /तै /ताहि.

ओहि /ओइ; सीखि /सीख; जीवि /जीवी /जीब; भले /भलेहीं /भलहिं.

तैं /तँइ /तँए; जाएब /जएब; लइ /लै; छइ /छै.

नहि /नै /नइ; गइ /गै; छनि /छन्हि; चुकल अछि /गेलगछि.

Writing a Maithili Ghazal

Roughly five to ten *sher* (couplets) will constitute a ghazal. But merely placing five or seven couplets one after another does not make a ghazal.

A few points must be borne in mind.

Just as the beginning and end of a line appear aligned when a Word document is justified, so, if the beginnings and ends of both lines of each couplet, and of all the couplets in a ghazal, correspond without any artificial justification, the lines may be said to belong to a single *bahr*. A series of such couplets may rightfully form part of a ghazal. In the Maithili context, this means employing the method of counting syllables in a syllabic metre:

A letter carrying a *halant* counts as zero; a conjunct letter counts as one; and each letter from अ to ह counts as one. On this basis, instead of the nineteen *bahrs*, one may use short, medium and long lines; there is no need to name them. Further, at the end of both lines of the first couplet, and at the end of the second line of every subsequent couplet, a word or group of words must recur as the *radīf*. Ghazals without a *radīf* are also possible; one may write a ghazal on a single theme, without a *matlā* or without a *maqta* (some people even begin with the *maqta*). These, however, are exceptions; and exceptions remain incomplete. There may be more than one *matlā*. Critics can disagree about which couplet is the *ḥusn-e-ghazal*, the finest couplet. The *qāfiya* normally occurs in every couplet, before the *radīf*. The rhyming word changes, though it can

occasionally be repeated. Close attention nevertheless reveals that, for rhyme to operate, some letters at the beginning, middle or end of those words remain unchanged. In other words, rhythm is essential.

Now let us hear some ghazals.

I

Everybody's talk was murmuring, brooding over me. (23 syllabic units; *radīf*: गुम्हराइत, "brooding"; *qāfiya* phrase: हमरा पर, "over me.") [Maithili: सब सबाइत गप्प छल तकैत हमरा पर गुम्हराइत]

It came, still half-asleep, and brooded over that very person. (23 syllabic units; *radīf*: गुम्हराइत; *qāfiya* phrase: ओकरा पर.) [Maithili: आबैत छल एखौंझाइत आ सेहो ओकरे पर गुम्हराइत]

Yes, O charioteer, will it come to pass, or will the spirit remain broken and subdued? (23 syllabic units.) [Maithili: हएत हँ सारथि की रहि जाएत चुकड़िऔने ओ मोन मारि]

With face turned away, it will not speak, yet will remain brooding in the mind. (23 syllabic units; *radīf*: गुम्हराइत; *qāfiya* phrase: मोन पर.) [Maithili: बाजत नै मुँह फुलौने, रहत मुदा मोन पर गुम्हराइत]

It said just this: inwardly that person is pleased, though the mind plays its tricks. (23 syllabic units.) [Maithili: ईह कहलकै जे, मोने-मोन प्रसन्न अछि ओ मारने गबदी]

"We know it all," they say; an unfamiliar seeming keeps brooding. (23 syllabic units; *radīf*: गुम्हराइत; *qāfiya* phrase: नियारे-भास पर.) [Maithili: बुझैए सभ हमहीं बुझै छी, नियारे-भास पर गुम्हराइत]

I shall settle all accounts with you and with your father too. (23 syllabic units.) [Maithili: माने तोहूँ आ तोहर बापो हमर सार सम्बन्ध फरिछा देबौ]

What chatterers they are! Faces turned aside, they brood upon the raised platform. (23 syllabic units; *radīf*: गुम्हराइत; *qāfiya* phrase: मचान पर.) [Maithili: गप्पी छथि! मुँह घुमेने देखैए कोना मचान पर गुम्हराइत]

It is not that I fail to understand; I understand it all, but perhaps the heart speaks otherwise. (23 syllabic units.) [Maithili: बुझै सभटा छी से नै जे नै बुझै छी मुदा मोना कहैए साइत]

In the wind it mutters, as though brooding over its very self. (23 syllabic units; *radīf*: गुम्हराइत; *qāfiya* phrase: स्वयम् पर.) [Maithili: बड़बड़ाइए बाइमे, माने अछि ओ स्वयम् पर गुम्हराइत]

"Airāvat," I have come to understand: this is the first night of creation. (23 syllabic units.) [Maithili: "ऐरावत"बुझैत बुझि गेल छी ई जे सृष्टिक पहिलुके राति]

All the characters watched, brooding over one another. (23 syllabic units; *radīf*: गुम्हराइत; *qāfiya* phrase: एक-दोसरा पर.) [Maithili: सभ चरित्र रहल देखैत, एक-दोसरा पर गुम्हराइत]

Let us now turn to some more difficult questions concerning the Maithili ghazal.

These questions involve difficulty, some variety and, in the Maithili context, a certain novelty; yet they are not altogether so difficult.

As already stated, Vedic and Maithili metres are counted by syllables; the distinction between *guru* and *laghu* does not arise there. Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas have been influenced by Classical Sanskrit and Hindi. The vocabulary of communities other than Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas, however, contains many words found in Vedic Sanskrit but not in Classical Sanskrit; in the author's view, their Maithili is therefore less adulterated and more authentic. Hence the need to count metre by syllables becomes still greater.

Gāyatrī: 24 syllables; Uṣṇih: 28 syllables; Anuṣṭubh: 32 syllables.

Bṛhatī: 36 syllables; Paṅkti: 40 syllables; Triṣṭubh: 44 syllables.

Jagatī: 48 syllables.

In the Ṛgveda, to which the Śūdra poet Ailuṣa and others contributed, the metres Gāyatrī, Triṣṭubh and Jagatī occur most frequently. Let us therefore consider these three.

Gāyatrī. This occurs in four forms: two-footed, three-footed, four-footed and five-footed. In the four-footed form there are eight syllables to each foot. One can place a semicolon after one foot and a full stop after two, thereby making a Gāyatrī couplet. Let me clarify here that Gāyatrī is a metre, not a mantra. What is commonly called the Gāyatrī Mantra is the

Sāvitrī mantra composed in Gāyatrī metre, and that too only if स्व is pronounced सुवः and वरेण्यम् as वरेणियम्.

Triṣṭubh. Four feet, with eleven syllables per foot. A semicolon may follow one foot and a full stop two feet, thus making a Triṣṭubh couplet.

Jagatī. Four feet, each of twelve syllables. A semicolon may follow one foot and a full stop two feet, thereby making a Jagatī couplet.

As mentioned earlier, Gāyatrī can contain one or two syllables fewer or more: from twenty-two to twenty-six syllables. Its varieties are Virāḍ Gāyatrī (22), Nicṛd Gāyatrī (23), Bhurig Gāyatrī (25) and Svarāḍ Gāyatrī (26). Thus there is scope for variation within the rules; the Maithili ghazal has not become metrically lawless. A full stop may, or may not, be placed at the end of a line of a ghazal.

I do not understand what Hindutva-isation would mean in relation to Persian poetics; nor do I understand how Hindutva could be introduced into the creation of an original ghazal. Poetry would be better kept away from the categories "Hindu" and "infidel." I have no objection, however, to the term "Maithili ghazal"; if someone calls that Hindutva-isation, the blame is not mine.

More poets and theorists of poetry have existed in Arabic and Persian than, taken together, in the rest of the world.

If I write a ghazal in Maithili, I shall write it according to prosody, and may employ Arabic-Persian prosody. But, besides that possibility, I believe the prosody of the Ṛgveda is more scientific and straightforward than the elaborate *ta-gaṇa* and *ma-gaṇa* calculations, and that it will make writing, reading and humming Maithili ghazals easier. The word "Hindu" had not even come into existence in the Vedic age; I therefore do not believe that using Vedic metre alone makes a Maithili ghazal Hindu.

When I wrote *A Theory of Maithili Haiku*, I also had to choose between syllabic and quantitative metre, and I chose syllabic counting. If we were to use the scripts and prosody of Japanese people following Shinto (and some Buddhists), Maithili haiku could never be written, because Japanese prosody is relative to the Japanese language and its several writing systems; religion had also entered it, as in the invocation of God in *tanka/waka*. The Arabic-Persian ghazal, by contrast, is secular; but its prosody is constructed for its own languages and scripts. Neither Japanese nor Arabic-Persian poetics can therefore be language-neutral.

And now let us compose ghazals.

A Gāyatrī Ghazal

Listen, see what has been done; who is this to whom? [Maithili: छै सुनि देखि कएल, छैक करासँ ककर]

What talk has been endured; who is this to whom? [Maithili: कोन गपक सहल, छैक करासँ ककर]

See what has been borne; what pain has risen? [Maithili: हे अछि देखि सहल, अछि की टीस उठल]

O, the known one was recognised; who is this to whom? [Maithili: रे चिन्हलकेँ चीन्हल, छैक करासँ ककर]

These all are companions of truth; all have changed their guise. [Maithili: ई सभ सत्यक संगी, सभ छै भेष बदलि]

Who has turned their face away; who is this to whom? [Maithili: के अछि मुँह फेरल, छैक करासँ ककर]

Look at this fleeting flash of light, like a moth. [Maithili: हे बिजुलौका देखियौ, छै उका पतङ्ग जेकाँ]

What has stunned the head; who is this to whom? [Maithili: की माथ सुन्न कएल, छैक करासँ ककर]

Fiery Maithili—will its current dry up? [Maithili: अगिनवान मैथिली, की सुखि जाएत धार]

What was said, and when; who is this to whom? [Maithili: कहैकिदनिकहल, छैक करासँ ककर]

What compromise should we make, what settlement? [Maithili: करू कोन समझौता, करू कोन निपटारा]

Who is issuing the challenge; who is this to whom? [Maithili: के ललकारि रहल, छैक करासँ ककर]

Who is raising whom, and who is bringing whom down? [Maithili: के अछि उठा रहल, अछि के झुका रहल]

Who is speaking; who is this to whom? [Maithili: के अछि बाजि रहल, छैक करासँ ककर]

Airāvat is astonished; what is he thinking? [Maithili: ऐरावत छै चकित, अछि की सोचि रहल]

This helmsman who has survived—who is this to whom? [Maithili: ई कर्णधार बँचल, छैक करासँ ककर]

A Triṣṭubh Ghazal

Look, standing beside the thief, watching the *ḍaklilāmī*. [Maithili: अछि चोरबा संग देखू ठाढ़, देखैत रहलि डकलिलामी]

It will no longer be endured: the calling and clamour of *ḍaklilāmī*. [Maithili: नहि होएत आब बरदास्त, डाक-डकौअलि डकलिलामी]

It was slipping away; will any food be found again? [Maithili: ई सुरकि रहल छल आब, नै भेटत आब फेर की खाद्य]

How did this disorder arise? The path survived, *ḍaklilāmī*. [Maithili: अछि कोना भेल ई असम्हार, डघर बचलि डकलिलामी]

How these restless people flutter—what is this of the road grown still? [Maithili: कोना तड़फड़िया सभ अछि, डगहर थस लेने की बात]

The father has found no peace; the river-mouth brings *ḍaklilāmī*. [Maithili: नञि निचेन भेल अछि बाप, ओ मुहानी आनि डकलिलामी]

Will this again become clear? What is this commotion now? [Maithili: औ बुझारति होएत फेरसँ, भेल की ई ढिंढम दरा आब]

The *ḍhābu* stands, with its *sabeṅg*; whose move is this, *ḍaklilāmī*? [Maithili: ई ढाबु सबेंगक अछि ठाढ़, ई ककर चालि डकलिलामी]

Calling out to the buffalo, calling again, he stands as if deaf. [Maithili: पुक्की पाड़िके रहल पुकारि, बहीर बनि भने अछि ठाढ़]

He will hear no one's plea: striking with the hammer, *ḍaklilāmī*. [Maithili: नहि ककरो सुनब पुकार, ई हथौड़ा मारि डकलिलामी]

Tell me, why do you still stand? The sound of Airāvat's snorting! [Maithili: कहू यौ किएक छीहू सठाढ़, ऐरावतक फोंफक अबाज]

Why stand mute, entranced by a taste of *ḍaklilāmī*? [Maithili: नहि किए बनल बौक ठाढ़, चिपैले सुआदि डकलिलामी]

A Jagatī Ghazal

This village made by God—when day breaks, *bakaṭeṇṭ*. [Maithili: भगवानक बनाओल ई गाम, जखन अछि हो भोर बकटेंट]

Otherwise, where will there be any respite; what has happened now, *bakaṭeṇṭ*? [Maithili: नहि तँ भेटत की कोनो विराम, अछि भेल कोना भेर बकटेंट]

Will there be no deliverance now? I have heard the same from those seeking refuge. [Maithili: औ की नहि भेटत आब हु त्राण, छी सुनल सएह सरनरिया]

How the *mṛdaṅga* player struck his drum: this lion-like *mirahannī*, *bakaṭeṇṭ*. [Maithili: कोना मिरदङिया देलक थाप, ई मिरहन्नी शेर बकटेंट]

Going and regretting, still regretting, finding no way ahead. [Maithili: जाए रहल पछताए रहल, नहि बाट कोनो सुझाए रहल]

This boy endures the *golhatthī* blows; *pañcāgī bihaṭār bakaṭeṇṭ*. [Maithili: अछि गोलहत्थी खाइत ई छौड़ा, पँचागिईबिहटारबकटेंट]

The fierce sun sinks, face turned down; the evening settles after its play. [Maithili: मोचण्ड बूड़ि रौद मुँहा होइत, साँझ कलक धक बैसि रहल]

Dust-covered, at every turn, they bring *ganaur bakaṭeṇṭ*. [Maithili: धमधूसर सभ बेर लगौरी, आनि रहल गनौर बकटेंट]

Strike, O *gadāre*, *guiṃ-guiṃ*; strike, O *gadāre*, *puiṃ-puiṃ*: the fist falls. [Maithili: गदारे गुइँ गुइँ मार गदारे, गदारे पुइँ पुइँ, मुक्का मारल]

A whole crowd of divers has set out: *gatā saṅga pathār bakaṭeṇṭ*. [Maithili: गताखोरक छै ई हेँज चलल, गतातसंगपथारबकटेंट]

Illness could no longer be warded off; to uncover all is to lose colour. [Maithili: बेराम पड़ब नै आउ सकल, बेपर्द करब बेदरंग भेल]

Airāvat, recognise the traders; trade in language, *bakaṭeṇṭ*. [Maithili: ऐरावत चीन्हि बेपारी सभकेँ, करू भाषाक व्यापार बकटेंट]

In Maithili and Sanskrit, end rhyme does not by itself create rhythm; yet it also contributes to rhythm.

From the standpoint of rhyme, certain letters at the beginning, middle and end of the words remain unchanged.

In *Ved-e-Muqaddas*, Ali Sardar Jafri writes of the Vedas: "*Shuūr-e-insāñ ke āftāb-e-ázīm kī avvalīñ shuāéñ*"—the first rays of the great sun of human consciousness.

Just as movements have arisen to exclude Sanskrit words from Tamil and Arabic words from Turkish, so in Persian there has been a movement to reject Arabic words and replace them with words of the Indo-Aryan linguistic family (compare the affinities between the ancient Persian Avesta and Vedic Sanskrit). In Maithili, too, excessive use of Hindi and Urdu vocabulary presents something like a crisis for the language's existence, particularly after the Mithilākṣara script was, in the author's expression, consigned to the funeral pyre by the Maithil Brahmin community.

Now let us turn to the Urdu ghazal. In 1893 Hali wrote *Muqaddama-e-Sher-o-Shāírī* as the introduction to his collection of poems. By then, the themes and form of the Urdu ghazal were almost moribund. Hali not only called for a change in subject matter, but advocated simpler forms of *qāfiya* and *radīf*. He wrote that nowadays perhaps one or two couplets were good, while the remainder of a ghazal became a collection of couplets overloaded with Persian words, thereby distracting readers from its inferior quality. The Urdu ghazal thus advanced beyond the Persian ghazal in the sphere of satire against religious orthodoxy.

Music and the Singing of Ghazals

Under *thāṭ* Kalyān, rāga Yaman can employ *tīntāl* of sixteen beats here (corresponding to the thirty-two syllables of a two-line Anuṣṭubh). In *thāṭ* Bilāval, rāga Bilāval uses a cycle of twelve beats; here a Gāyatrī ghazal of twenty-four syllables can be used. After syllabic counting, the singer can prolong the notes without needing to sing fewer words or finding a shortage of syllables.

These are examples for singers alone, not prescriptions for writers of Maithili ghazals.

No attention has yet been paid to uniformity of *bahr* in the ghazals written in Maithili: not according to Persian poetics, nor according to Indian poetics. For that reason, Maithili ghazals can at present be called only "poems resembling ghazals." In fact, a ghazal writer could establish uniform metre by spending merely half an hour on a ghazal after writing it.

Ghazal

A millennium's defeat is mine, the victory theirs; I shall not stand diminished before casteists. [Maithili: सहस्राब्दीक हारि हमर आ जीत ओकर, नै जातिवादीक सोझाँ होएब लरताङर]

Changing their disguises, the caste partisans win, O poet; I shall not become another Ailuṣa and stand diminished. [Maithili: भेष बदलि जातिपंथी जीति रहल कवि, ऐलुष नै फेर हम बनब लरताङर]

How strange is the tale of this earthly road: light has arrived and the darkness has receded. [Maithili: एहि भू मार्गक अछि तँ गप्पे विचित्र सन, प्रकाश आएल अछि भेल अन्हार निवृत्त]

The peacock-feathered water-drawer rises even now; I shall absorb Indra's cloud and not be diminished. [Maithili: मयूरपंखी पनि सोखा उगल छै एखने, इन्द्रक मेघकेँ सोंखि करब लरताङर]

Like a child, I asked today: is this the path of truth and non-violence, the path of victory? [Maithili: बनि बाल बुद्धि हम पुछने आइ छलहुँ, ई सत्य अहिंसाक पथ ई विजयक पथ]

Their chariot of falsehood wins; I shall not tremble or stand diminished again. [Maithili: जीतल जाइए असत्यक रथ हुनकर, टनकाएब नै फेर होएब लरताङर]

Day and night I travelled the road, always; it turns to ashes and another road appears. [Maithili: रस्ता चलैत छलहुँ दिन राति सदिखन, से भेल जाइत छारन नव रस्ता बनल]

I see the road shedding its old skin; I shall go forward and not be diminished. [Maithili: छी देखि रहल रस्ताक केंचुली भरि गर, गऽ जाइत आगाँ नहि होएब लरताङर]

The moment of truth arrives in the form of some calamity; the double-dealer has come, bewildered. [Maithili: अबैए ओ सत्यक क्षण कोन विपदा बनि, अछि आएल दौगल ओ सुनझाएल अछि]

I stand on the rim of the pond; I shall not cause the home to crumble, nor stand diminished. [Maithili: पोखरिक जाइठ पर भेल ठाढ़ छी हम, छछड़बाएब घर नै हैब लरताङर]

Having drunk poison, Śiva looks in every direction; the destroyer of poison moves like the wind. [Maithili: छनगा पीबि शिव देखि रहल चारू कात, विषहन्त ओ घूमि रहल बनल बसात]

Your intellect calls this *trikaṭu*, this Tāṇḍava; I shall not be driven into humiliation. [Maithili: तांडव ई अहाँक बुद्धि कहैए से त्रिकटु, तगबाएत करा नै होएब लरताङर]

Brother, Airāvat sways today, stamping a formidable rhythm in the mud. [Maithili: हे भाइ ऐरावत अछि आइ झूमि रहल, कदैमे करैत ओ कदम ताल विकराल]

I have seen the spindle of the woman at her spinning wheel; I shall not be dismayed or diminished. [Maithili: चरखा कत्तिनक टकुआ काटब देखल, नहि कदरियाएब खोभब लरताङर]

Ghazal

This rainy night has become a night of delight, O Kāli. [Maithili: बरसातिक ई राति बनल सुख राति हेकालि]

I shall offer the sixteen forms of worship and sacrifice my heart, O Kāli. [Maithili: करब षोडशोपचार आ रदए बलि हेकालि]

May brother Bāl Basant grow; such is the sister's hope. [Maithili: बाल बसन्त भैया बढ़थु बहिनक अछि आस]

Performing *āstik* rites, the brother has not even remembered her, O Kāli. [Maithili: आस्ती क करैत भैया लेल सुधियो नहि हेकालि]

Red cricket, red vermilion, red hibiscus flower— [Maithili: लाल झिंगुर, लाल सिन्दुर, लाल अड़हुल फूल]

Redder still is the sight of this land of Mithila, O Kāli. [Maithili: ताहूसँ लाल देखल ई दृश्य-देश मिथि हे कालि]

Before a dream, truth now has no worth. [Maithili: स्वप्नक सोझाँ सत्यक नै अछि आब कोनो मोल]

Wandering among ponds and thickets, I saw this everywhere, O Kāli. [Maithili: पोखड़ि झाँखड़ि सगरि घूमि ई देखलिहे कालि]

The mango has fruited; the branch is lowered, bending and bending. [Maithili: अमुआ फड़ एल दाल दी डारि लीबि-लीबिजाए]

In its humility I heard no restlessness, O Kāli. [Maithili: ओकर नम्रतामे कोनो अगुताइ सुनलिहे कालि]

Airāvat has offered, behold, this poem resembling a ghazal. [Maithili: ऐरावत गजल सन कविता देखू देलनि ई]

Behold here the dignity of Maithili, always, O Kāli. [Maithili: मैथिलीक गरिमा एहि ठाँ देखू सदति हे कालि]

Ghazal

As I passed, I saw that figure standing: a chest like a great thundercloud. [Maithili: जाइत-जाइत देखल ओ ठाढ़ आर मेघडम्बर सन छाती]

The brother's back is like the washerman's slab; his chest like a great thundercloud. [Maithili: भैयाक पीठ धोबिया पाट हुनकर मेघडम्बर सन छाती]

Famine fell again; crying aloud, the figure stood aside. [Maithili: पड़ल फेर अकाल करैत हाक्रोस छथि ओ ठाढ़ भेल कात]

The chest beats, proudly upright at the threshold: a chest like a great thundercloud. [Maithili: छाती धकधक उन्नत्त ठाढ़ि दुआर मेघडम्बर सन छाती]

I have heard this outcry; standing before them I shall offer encouragement. [Maithili: देखल ई चित्कार हम भऽ सोझाँ ठाढ़ देबै ओकरा हुतकारी]

Through the blows of crisis, boundless patience: a chest like a great thundercloud. [Maithili: संकट प्रहार मे धैर्य अपरम्पार मेघडम्बर सन छाती]

Today I saw their exhausted face, but they uttered no complaint. [Maithili: देखल हुनका आइ छन्हि मुँह क्लान्त मुदा नहि कोनो बात]

On the road of duty there is no rest: a chest like a great thundercloud. [Maithili: कर्तव्यक बिच कोनो विश्राम डगर मेघडम्बर सन छाती]

Listen, brother, disorder has overcome us; raise a cry for resolution. [Maithili: सुनू सुनू भाइ गप भेल असम्हार करू पुकार समधानि]

See what has become of humankind; rebuke it with a chest like a great thundercloud. [Maithili: भेल मानवक ई हाल करू दुत्कार मेघडम्बर सन छाती]

Airāvat saw the turning course become a weapon, a net held in the hand. [Maithili: ऐरावत देखल घुर चालि बनल हथियार ओ लेने जाल]

Even so, we stand—are we beyond the horizon?—with chests like great thunderclouds. [Maithili: छी तैयो ठाढ़ की हम क्षितिजक पार मेघडम्बर सन छाती]

Let us now examine some terminology.

Arkān: the complete metrical feet (*arkān-e-sālim*).

The complete metrical feet are: *fa-ū-lun* (U। ।); *fā-i-lun* (। U।); *mafā-ī-lun* (U। । ।); *mus-taf-i-lun* (। । U।); *fā-i-lā-tun* (। U। ।); *mu-ta-fā-i-lun* (UU। U।); *mafā-i-la-tun* (U। UU।); and *maf-ū-lā-tu* (। । । U). [Original scansion: फ–ऊ–लुन U। ।; फा–इ–लुन । U।; मफा–ई–लुन U। । ।; मुस–तफ–इ–लुन । । U।; फा–इ–ला–तुन । U। ।; मु–त–फा–इ–लुन UU। U।; मफा–इ–ल–तुन U। UU।; मफ–ऊ–ला–तु । । । U.]

These complete-foot components have numerous varieties.

From ten complete (*sālim*) *arkān* come nineteen *bahrs*, of two kinds.

The *mufrad bahr* is formed by repeating a *rukn* (metrical foot). Seven are *sālim* (complete) metres, which in musical terminology may be called

pure. By repeating the foot two to eight times in every line, a couplet will contain a metre of four to sixteen *rukns*.

A four-*rukn* metre is *murabbaʿ*; a six-*rukn* metre is *musaddas*; an eight-*rukn* metre is *musamman/mufrad* (pure). There are *sālim* metres of eight, six and four feet.

Hazaj: eight feet—*mafāīlun* (U| | |), repeated four times; six feet—the same foot repeated three times; four feet—the same foot repeated twice.

Rajaz: eight feet—*mustafīlun* (| | U|), repeated four times; six feet—the same foot repeated three times; four feet—the same foot repeated twice.

Ramal: eight feet—*fāīlātun* (| U| |), repeated four times; six feet—the same foot repeated three times; four feet—the same foot repeated twice.

Wāfir: eight feet—*mafāīlatun* (U| UU|), repeated four times; six feet—the same foot repeated three times; four feet—the same foot repeated twice.

Kāmil: eight feet—*mutafāīlun* (UU| U|), repeated four times; six feet—the same foot repeated three times; four feet—the same foot repeated twice.

Mutaqārib: eight feet—*faūlun* (U| |), repeated four times; six feet—the same foot repeated three times; four feet—the same foot repeated twice.

Mutadārik: eight feet—*fāīlun* (| U|), repeated four times; six feet—the same foot repeated three times; four feet—the same foot repeated twice.

All these metres also possess numerous forms with modified or incomplete feet.

Murakkab bahr (compound metre): twelve complete (*sālim*) metres arise through the repeated alternation of two kinds of *arkān*. In the terminology of music, these may be called mixed metres. They occur in three lengths: metres of four, six, and eight *rukns*. These are the compound (*murakkab*), complete-foot (*sālim*) metres.

The twelve are *Tawīl, Madīd, Munsariḥ, Muqtadab, Muḍāriʿ, Mujtathth, Khafīf, Basīṭ, Sarīʿ, Jadīd, Qarīb,* and *Mushākil*.

Arkān: the modified (muẓāḥif) or incomplete metrical feet.

The modified (*muẓāḥif*) feet include: *faīlun* (UU|); *mafāīlun* (U| U|); *faīlātun* (UU| |); *mafāīlu* (U| | U); *muftaīlun* (| UU|); *faūlu* (U| U);

mafūlu (। । U); *mafūlun* (। । ।); *faʿlun* (। ।); *fā* (।); *faʿal* (U।); *faʿul* (U। U); *fāʿ* (। U); *fāʿilun* (। U।); and *faʿūlun* (U। ।). The source gives their syllabic patterns in this order.

Muqtadab (eight modified feet): *faʿūlu* (U। U) – *faʿilun* (U।) – *faʿūlu* (U। U) – *faʿilun* (। ।). [Original metrical string: फऊलुU। UफैलुनU। फऊलुU। Uफैलुन। ।]

Muḍāriʿ (eight modified feet): *mafūlu* (। । U) – *fāʿilātu* (। U। U) – *mafāʿilu* (U। । U) – *fāʿilun* (। U।), or *fāʿilān* (। U। U). [Original: मफऊलु। । Uफाइलातु। U। UमफाईलुU। । Uफाइलुन। U।/फाइलान। U। U]

Mujtathth (eight modified feet): *mafāʿilun* (U। U।) – *faʿilātun* (UU। ।) – *mafāʿilun* (U। U।) – *faʿlun* (। ।), or *faʿilun* (UU।).

Khafīf (six modified feet): *fāʿilātun* (। U। ।) – *mafāʿilun* (U। U।) – *faʿlun* (। ।), or *faʿilun* (UU।).

Let us return once again to the instructions for Maithili pronunciation and the distinction between short and long vowels.

Just as it was explained earlier that an *anusvāra* or *visarga* makes a syllable long, the point now is that a *candrabindu* combined with a short vowel still constitutes a short syllable.

That is: candrabindu + short vowel = one *mātrā*.

Conjunct consonants: for the following combinations, the *mātrās* are counted in this manner:

क्ति = क् + त् + इ = ० + ० + १ = १.

क्ती = क् + त् + ई = ० + ० + २ = २.

Let us now consider the final letter of a line, or of a segment of a line.

क्ष = क् + ष = ० + १; त्र = त् + र = ० + १; ज्ञ = ज् + ञ = ० + १.

श्र = श् + र = ० + १; स्र = स् + र = ० + १; शृ = श् + ऋ = ० + १.

त्व = त् + व = ० + १; त्त्व = त् + त् + व = ० + ० + १.

Short vowel + avagraha (ऽ) = 1 + 0.

An avagraha (*bikārī*) should not be used after *a* or a long vowel: forms such as दिअऽ, आऽ, and ओऽ are erroneous. It may, however, be used after a consonant combined with the inherent *a*.

Short vowel + candrabindu = 1 + 0; long vowel + candrabindu = 2 + 0.

For example, हँसल = 1 + 1 + 1; साँस = 2 + 1.

For metrical counting, both the avagraha and the candrabindu have a value of zero.

जाकऽ = 2 + 1; क् = 0; क = क् + अ = 0 + 1.

A tendency has arisen in Maithili to pronounce क as क्, hence the need to mark the inherent vowel by an avagraha; no such mark is needed for a long vowel.

U denotes a short syllable.

I denotes a long syllable.

One long syllable (I) is equivalent to two short syllables (U U) in quantitative value.

Bahr-e-Mutaqārib: in every line a metrical unit of five letters is repeated four times in the following order:

UI I — a complete (*sālim*) metrical foot.

In Maithili, attaching case suffixes to the preceding word offers some convenience. A line may consequently contain more than four words; the sequence of short and long syllables must nevertheless remain unchanged.

Faūlun — UI I.

Faūlun | *faūlun* | *faūlun* | *faūlun*.

Faūlun | *faūlun* | *faūlun* | *faūlun*.

Example 1.

Bahr-e-Mutaqārib: 8 feet, *faūlun* (UI I) repeated 4 times in each line.

अनेरे धुनेरे जते कोठ केलौं

बकै तो ढ़ कै तोसुझेलौंघनेरौं

Example 2.

Bahr-e-Mutadārik: 8 feet, *fāilun* (। U।) repeated 4 times in each line.

बी कि गेलै तँ की जोतबैखेतमे

झी किलेतैतँ की बोल तै बेरमे

Example 3.

Bahr-e-Kāmil: 8 feet, *mutafāilun* (UU। U।) repeated 4 times in each line.

The person called human feels ashamed if deceived. [Maithili metrical specimen: इनसान जे कहबैत छै सकुचा कऽ छै जँ ठकैल यौ]

One who speaks out but cannot endure the response is weak. [Maithili metrical specimen: बहरा कऽ जे कहतै जँ नै सहि ते तँ छै कमजोर यौ]

Example 4.

Bahr-e-Wāfir: 8 feet, *mafāilatun* (U। UU।) repeated 4 times in each line.

That person comes, listens, and, if departing, sits down. [Maithili metrical specimen: अबै अछि ओ सुनै अछि ओ जँ जाइत छैबसै अछि ओ]

That person speaks and hears; if eating, pushes it away. [Maithili metrical specimen: कहै अछि जे सुनै अछि ओ जँ खाइत छैढकै अछि ओ]

Example 5.

Bahr-e-Ramal: 8 feet, *fāilātun* (। U। ।) repeated 4 times in each line.

झूरझा मो भेल छी से बात ने कीकाटने की

सेसमे टू सेलपेटूआर की की आर ने छी

Example 6.

Bahr-e-Rajaz: 8 feet, *mustafilun* (। । U।) repeated 4 times in each line.

ऐओतऽ की छैकेहनोआ की अ ते की छी अए

नै छै कएलो नै सुनै छै की करै भेटैत-ए

Example 7.

Bahr-e-Hazaj: 8 feet, *mafāīlun* (U। । ।) repeated 4 times in each line.

He neither comes nor listens; even while out, he understands. [Maithili metrical specimen: अबै छै नै सुनै छै नैबहीरो छै बुझै छै से]

If I am in distress, what is cut away? He understands even the passing night. [Maithili metrical specimen: नरैमे छी कटै की सेज जातो छै बुझै छै से]

1. We shall now examine the eight-foot, six-foot (the foot occurring three times), and four-foot (twice) uses of the complete *arkān*. These are *mufrad* metres: a single metrical foot is repeatedly employed.

2. There are additionally twelve compound (*murakkab*) metres made from complete feet. Here two kinds of feet recur in alternation, producing what may be called mixed metres in music. They have four, six, or eight feet. These twelve complete (*sālim*) metres are Tawīl, Madīd, Munsariḥ, Muqtadab, Muḍāriʿ, Mujtaththh, Khafīf, Basīṭ, Sarīʿ, Jadīd, Qarīb, and Mushākil.

3. A further twelve metres are produced by combining complete (*sālim*) and modified (*muẓāḥif*) feet: Makhbūn, Akhrab, Maḥdhūf, Maqṭūʿ, Maqbūḍ, Muḍmar, Marfūʿ, Maʿṣūb, Maḥdhūdh, Makfūf, Mashkūl, and Aslam.

4. Four relatively common metres constructed solely from modified feet are Muqtadab, Muḍāriʿ, Mujtaththh, and Khafīf.

Bahr-e-Mutaqārib: 6 feet, *faūlun* (U। ।) repeated 3 times in each line.

एकेबेरमेजेकएलौं

बड़ेभेरभेनैंसुनेलौं

Bahr-e-Mutaqārib: 4 feet, *faūlun* (U। ।) repeated 2 times in each line.

Standing very far away. [Maithili metrical specimen: बड़ीदूरठाढ़े]

Dancing a little distance away. [Maithili metrical specimen: कनीदूरनाचे]

Bahr-e-Mutadārik: 6 feet, *fāīlun* (। U।) repeated 3 times in each line.

एकरेकेलहाकेलहीं

तैं अनेरे दुर्गा भेलहीं

Bahr-e-Mutadārik: 4 feet, *fāʿilun* (। U।) repeated 2 times in each line.

Why should it be cut? [Maithili metrical specimen: काहिकाटीएतै]

Why should the matter be divided? [Maithili metrical specimen: बातबाँटीएतै]

Bahr-e-Hazaj: 6 feet, *mafāʿīlun* (U। । ।) repeated 3 times in each line.

अनेरे भऽ गेलैं ऐ लड़ै ले गै

तखैनो जे भऽ जेतै की गमैए गै

Bahr-e-Hazaj: 4 feet, *mafāʿīlun* (U। । ।) repeated 2 times in each line.

A little unpaid labour, illness. [Maithili metrical specimen: कनेबेगारबेमारी]

How many things shall I tell? [Maithili metrical specimen: कतेकीबातसुनाबी]

Bahr-e-Rajaz: 6 feet, *mustafʿilun* (। । U।) repeated 3 times in each line.

ई जेधरा देखैसँछैहेतैतँनै

ई जे घटाघूमैसँघूमैनै तँ नै

Bahr-e-Rajaz: 4 feet, *mustafʿilun* (। । U।) repeated 2 times in each line.

Who arrived this morning, girl? [Maithili metrical specimen: भोरेअएलैकोनगै]

Why did the telephone not come directly, girl? [Maithili metrical specimen: सोझेनएलैफोनगै]

Bahr-e-Ramal: 6 feet, *fāʿilātun* (। U। ।) repeated 3 times in each line.

कीगरीबोकी धनी को तैंसभैछी

कीसमी पो की कतेको जेघुमैछी

Bahr-e-Ramal: 4 feet, *fāʿilātun* (। U। ।) repeated 2 times in each line.

How many things happened? [Maithili metrical specimen: कीकतेकोबातभेलै]

How many kicks were received? [Maithili metrical specimen: कीजतेकोलातखेलै]

Bahr-e-Wāfir: 6 feet, *mafāīlatun* (U। UU।) repeated 3 times in each line.

कनेक करा कहेबइ आब तेबइ की

जते सुनबैत ते कहताबतेबइकी

Bahr-e-Wāfir: 4 feet, *mafāīlatun* (U। UU।) repeated 2 times in each line.

How many words lie in the heart? [Maithili metrical specimen: करेजकबातछैकतबो]

This, then, is the condition of the heart. [Maithili metrical specimen: करेजकहालईनञिहो]

Bahr-e-Kāmil: 6 feet, *mutafāīlun* (UU। U।) repeated 3 times in each line.

अनका कतौ कहबै कनेसुनतै कहाँ

सुनि ओबजौकरतै कनेजितबैजहाँ

Bahr-e-Kāmil: 4 feet, *mutafāīlun* (UU। U।) repeated 2 times in each line.

First it comes, then it listens. [Maithili metrical specimen: पहिलेअनैतखनेसुनै]

How much it says, how much it does. [Maithili metrical specimen: कहबैकतेकखनोकरै]

Bahr-e-Tawīl: faʿūlun (U। ।) – mafāʿīlun (U। । ।).

Shall I tell or listen? Yet whatever that person says... [Maithili metrical specimen: कहेबैसुनेबैकी मुदा जेकहेतै से]

Shall I hear that person as well? Yet whatever that person speaks... [Maithili metrical specimen: सुने तैउकारोकी मुदा जेबजेतै से]

Bahr-e-Madīd: fāʿilātun (। U। ।) – fāʿilun (। U।).

Speak after listening: how many things are in your mouth? [Maithili metrical specimen: सूनिबाजूमूँहमे कैकटा छै बातमे]

Understand before speaking, friend: how many blows lie in the matter? [Maithili metrical specimen: बूझि बाजू मीत यौ कैकटा छैघातमे]

Bahr-e-Munsariḥ: mustafʿilun (। । U।) – mafʿūlātu (। । । U).

की की रहै की की भेल कोनोभलाकोनो सैह

माँ माँ करी पैघो भेल सेहो जरौ सेहो जैह

Bahr-e-Muqtadab: mafʿūlātu (। । । U) – mustafʿilun (। । U।).

Raise the name of Rāma as well; awaken the name of Rāma. [Maithili metrical specimen: रामोनाम सेहोउठारामोनामसेहो जरा]

Take the name of Rāma too; utter the name of Rāma. [Maithili metrical specimen: रामोनाम मो हो लएरामोनाम बा तो करा]

Bahr-e-Muḍāriʿ: mafāʿīlun (U। । ।) – fāʿilātun (। U। ।).

अरे की छी सैह नै की अरे छी छी वैह ने छी

बिसारीकीउघारीकी अरे की की देब ने की

Bahr-e-Mujtathth: mustafʿilun (। । U।) – fāʿilātun (। U। ।).

No, Rāmā is not there; nor do I remain; neither dying nor dead. [Maithili metrical specimen: नै छै रमा नै रही मो नै छैमरा नैमरीजो]

This is not even a little dead; this is not even a little alive. [Maithili metrical specimen: नै ई कनेकोमृतो छै नै ई कनेको जि यै ओ]

Bahr-e-Khafīf: fāʿilātun (। U। ।) – mustafʿilun (। । U।) – fāʿilātun (। U। ।).

रे खरा खू फेकू तँ नै देख लेलौं

सूनिराखूबेरोतँ नै बीति गेलौं

Bahr-e-Basīṭ: mustafʿilun (। । U।) – fāʿilun (। U।).

What remained, what happened; what was there and what did not happen? [Maithili metrical specimen: की की रहै की भऽगैकी की छलै की भऽ नै]

The season passes unspoken; the song passes unsung. [Maithili metrical specimen: री तो बि तै ने कऽगैगीतोबि तै गाबि नै]

Bahr-e-Sarīʿ: mustafʿilun (। । U।) – mustafʿilun (। । U।) – mafʿūlātu (। । । U).

सेहो कने छै ने अते की के हैत

लेरोचुबै छै ने अ ते की के हैत

Bahr-e-Jadīd: fāʿilātun (। U। ।) – fāʿilātun (। U। ।) – mustafʿilun (। । U।).

लेलहँ ई बेगुणो आ भेलै भने

बेलगोईनैहरोआगेलैभने

Bahr-e-Qarīb: mafāʿīlun (U। । ।) – mafāʿīlun (U। । ।) – fāʿilātun (। U। ।).

It travels a little, yet goes nowhere along the road. [Maithili metrical specimen: चलै छै ई कने बाटो जाइ छै नै]

गतातो मे भने कोनो बाइ छै नै

Bahr-e-Mushākil: fāʿilātun (। U। ।) – mafāʿīlun (U। । ।) – mafāʿīlun (U। । ।).

Accept delight—ah, is there no share of fortune? [Maithili metrical specimen: मोद मानी अहो भागी क नै छै की]

Know anger: is an empty vow what comes to be? [Maithili metrical specimen: क्रोध जानी प्रणोखालीबनैछैकी]

Makhbūn: bahr-e-Ramal musaddas makhbūn.

Fāilātun (। U। ।) – *failātun* (UU। ।) – *failātun* (UU। ।).

खेलखेलाअसलीऐअगबेनै

मिलमिला अँखि गौरो बतहे नै

Akhrab: bahr-e-Hazaj murabbaʿ akhrab.

Mafūlu (। । U) – *mafāīlun* (U। । ।).

कीभेललटूबूडू

केगेलअत्तेजोडू

Maḥdhūf: bahr-e-Ramal musamman maḥdhūf.

Fāílātun (। U। ।) – *fāílātun* (। U। ।) – *fāílātun* (। U। ।) – *fāílun* (। U।).

एन मे नो भेल गेलौ आशआगाँबीतलौ

सूनिगेलौं नैभगेलौं नाश नारा गीत यौ

Maqṭūʿ: bahr-e-Mutadārik musaddas maqṭūʿ.

Fāílun (। U।) – *fāílun* (। U।) – *falun* (। ।).

What has become of what, sir? [Maithili metrical specimen: कीसँकीभेलछीबाबू]

What did you do with what next? [Maithili metrical specimen: कीसँकीकैलछीआगू]

Maqbūḍ: bahr-e-Mutaqārib musamman maqbūḍ (all the feet here are modified, *muẓāḥif*).

Faūlun (U। ।) – *faūlun* (U। ।) – *faūlun* (U। ।) – *faūlu* (U। U).

Ah, the affection that you spoke of! [Maithili metrical specimen: अरे रे अहाँ जे कहेलौंसिनेह]

Ah, the affection that you uttered! [Maithili metrical specimen: अरे रे अहाँ जेबजेलौंसिनेह]

Muḍmar: bahr-e-Kāmil musaddas muḍmar (the source describes the feet here as complete, *sālim*).

Mutafāílun (UU। U।) – *mutafāílun* (UU। U।) – *mustafílun* (। । U।).

अनठयने रहबैरहबैहरे हेरोमबै

अनठयने रहबैरहबैअरे हेघूरिऐ

Marfūʿ: bahr-e-Muqtadab musaddas marfūʿ.

Mafūlātu (। । । U) – *mafūlātu* (। । । U) – *mafūlu* (। । U).

की की रेह की की सैह निंघेस

की की रेह की की यैह निंघेस

Maʿṣūb: bahr-e-Wāfir musaddas (the source describes the feet here as complete, *sālim*).

Mafāīlatun (U। UU।) – *mafāīlatun* (U। UU।) – *mafāīlun* (U। । ।).

Ah, I have brought the married woman; why so needlessly? [Maithili metrical specimen: अरे अनलौं सुहागिन यै अनेरो की]

अरे अनलौं मुहोथरि मे जनेरो की

Maḥdhūdh: bahr-e-Mutadārik musamman maḥdhūdh (all feet are modified, *muẓāḥif*).

Fāīlun (। U।) – *fāīlun* (। U।) – *fāīlun* (। U।) – *fā* (।).

Who is there? Listen, you! [Maithili metrical specimen: केरहैसूनियैईअहाँकेँ]

Who is there? Why jump, you? [Maithili metrical specimen: केरहैकूदियैईअहाँकेँ]

Makfūf: bahr-e-Hazaj musamman makfūf.

Mafāīlun (U। । ।) – *mafāīlun* (U। । ।) – *mafāīlun* (U। । ।) – *mafāīlu* (U। । U).

अनेरे की अनेरे कीधुनेरेकीकहेलौंहँ

अनेरे की अनेरे कीधुनेरेकीकहेलौंहँ

Mashkūl: bahr-e-Ramal musamman mashkūl.

Fāīlātun (। U। ।) – *fāīlātun* (। U। ।) – *fāīlātun* (। U। ।) – *mafūlu* (। । U).

सूनि सुन्झा केलियै ने कोन पा पीछोड़ाइ

सूनि सुन्झा केलियै ने कोन पा पीछोड़ाइ

Aslam: bahr-e-Mutaqārib musaddas aslam.

Faūlun (U। ।) – *faūlun* (U। ।) – *faa̐l* (U।).

Oh, why, oh, why—you! [Maithili metrical specimen: अरेकीअरेकीअहाँ]

Oh, why, oh, why—you! [Maithili metrical specimen: अरेकीअरेकीअहाँ]

Bahr-e-Muqtadab, modified form (eight modified feet): *faūlu* (U। U) – *faílun* (U।) – *faūlu* (U। U) – *faílun* (। ।). [Original sequence: बहरेमुक्तजब (मुजाहिफरूप) (अपूर्णाक्षरीआठरुक्न): फऊलुU। UफैलुनU। फऊलुU। Uफैलुन। ।]

How many words, how many truths? [Maithili metrical specimen: कतेकगपोकतेकसप्पो]

How often does that happen? [Maithili metrical specimen: कतेकमिलैरहैतछैओ]

Bahr-e-Muḍāri‘, modified form (eight modified feet): *mafūlu* (। । U) – *fāílātu* (। U। U) – *mafāīlu* (U। । U) – *fāílun* (। U।), or *fāílān* (। U। U). [Original sequence: बहरेमज़ारे (मुजाहिफरूप) (अपूर्णाक्षरीआठरुक्न): मफऊलु। । Uफाइलातु। U। UमफाईलुU। । Uफाइलुन। U।/फाइलान। U। U]

ने छैक नैइनामकतेकोनछानिगै

ने छैक नैनकाम कतेकोनकानिगै

Bahr-e-Mujtathth, modified form (eight modified feet): *mafāílun* (U। U।) – *faílātun* (UU। ।) – *mafāílun* (U। U।) – *faılun* (। ।), or *faílun* (UU।).

Even if it is done well, perhaps good may come. [Maithili metrical specimen: भने भले करतै की भने भलेभेटौ]

How much fire may remain? How much may one see? [Maithili metrical specimen: कतेक तेज रतै ई कतेक ने देखौ]

Bahr-e-Khafif, modified form (six modified feet): *fāílātun* (। U। ।) – *mafāílun* (U। U।) – *faılun* (। ।), or *faílun* (UU।).

I have seen it, at times sold from the wall. [Maithili metrical specimen: देख लेलौं दिवारसँ बेचै कखनो]

बेख देखै गछारसँ हे तैनिक ओ

A ghazal should convey some message, emotional expression, philosophy of life, beauty, or the beauty of love and separation. Its effects should arise spontaneously, rather than through an obvious contrivance. Thus, like other verse or poetry, a ghazal ought to be *spoken* or *uttered*, not merely written. What one writes, in a different sense, is a picture: in Mithila

painting, the artist is called a *likhiyā*, one who writes or paints the picture; Sanskrit likewise has *ahaṃ citraṃ likhāmi*—"I paint a picture." The subject matter of the ghazal is distinct. A devotional hymn written according to the technical rules of ghazal prosody does not thereby become a ghazal. In Arabic, indeed, the word *ghazal* denotes conversation with a woman. Beyond love and separation, beyond failure to attain love, beyond social scandal and even after love has been deemed illicit, the ghazal draws upon the aesthetic savour of love. It may be love between God and a devotee, physical or spiritual love, Rādhā's love or Mīrā's. Nor need love be reciprocated. When emotion surges forth, the ghazal poet must transform its momentary intensity into an experience that is real and lasting; only then can a fine ghazal be composed.

Rubāʿī.

In the quatrain called *rubāī*, the first, second, and fourth lines rhyme, and each line has twenty or twenty-one *mātrās*.

Keep the line length of a *rubāī* at twenty or twenty-one *mātrās*. Every line begins in one of two ways: (1) long–long–long (*mafūlu*, ⏑ – – U, as given in the source), or (2) long–long–short (*mafūlun*, ⏑ – – –, as given in the source).

Persian *rubāī* prescribes the subsequent sequence of short and long syllables as well. For Maithili, however, one may choose any twenty- or twenty-one-*mātrā* metre beginning with either of these two patterns. The essential conditions remain the twenty- or twenty-one-*mātrā* line and the specified opening sequence.

The lines of one *rubāī* may nevertheless employ more than one metre or rhythmic movement. It is also possible to rhyme all four lines.

Another quatrain in which the first, second, and fourth lines rhyme, but whose lines do not have twenty or twenty-one *mātrās*, is not a *rubāī*.

In Maithili, however, such a composition may fall under the definition of *qiṭa* if it begins with two long syllables, while the remaining metre is simple syllabic, regulated syllabic, or quantitative. A *qiṭa* must open with long–long; thereafter, one may compose the couplet in any of these three systems. At a minimum, the second and fourth lines must rhyme.

The fourth line of the *rubāī* quatrain should carry the emotional culmination.

A Rubāʿī

In the dark black clouds, something is being brought. [Maithili metrical specimen: कारीअनहारमेघ, आनैहोइए]

Somewhere, sandy earth is being eaten away. [Maithili metrical specimen: कत्तौबलुआमाटि, खानैहोइए]

Seeing the burning earth, the clouds surge. [Maithili metrical specimen: दाहीजरतीदेखि, हिलोरै-एमेघ]

A firefly flares and departs, as though alive. [Maithili metrical specimen: भगजोगनीभकरार, जानैहोइए]

Correspondences between Bahr and Chhand

A ghazal must be composed in some *bahr* (metre). Even in a syllabic metre, account can be taken of short and long syllables; this distinction subsequently came to be observed in Sanskrit quantitative-syllabic metres derived from Vedic prosody. For example:

"I remain gazing towards this cloud." [Maithili: तकैत रहैत छी ऐ मेघ दिस]

तकैत (short + long + long): three syllables.

रहैत (short + long + short): three syllables.

छी (long): one syllable.

ऐ (long): one syllable.

मेघ (long + short): two syllables.

दिस (short + short): two syllables.

In quantitative (*mātrik*) metres, groups of two, three, four, five, and six *mātrās* (*dvikal, trikal, catuṣkal, pañcakal,* and *ṣaṭkal*) may be formed from as few as one syllable (one long) to as many as six syllables (six short).

A *dvikal* has two *mātrās*: either one long syllable or two short ones.

A *trikal* has three *mātrās*, arranged as short + long, long + short, or short + short + short.

A *catuṣkal* has four *mātrās*, a *pañcakal* five, and a *ṣaṭkal* six.

There are eight kinds of three-syllable units in regulated syllabic metre. They can be memorised through the formula "yamātārājasalagām."

The number of feet and the placement of rhyme, caesura (*yati*), and end-rhyme (*antyānuprāsa*) may then be determined on a syllabic or quantitative basis, allowing variation in the pattern.

In *varṇa* metre, a group of three syllables is called a *gaṇa*. There are eight such groups:

Ya-gaṇa: U|| .

Ra-gaṇa: |U| .

Ta-gaṇa: ||U .

Bha-gaṇa: |U U .

Ja-gaṇa: U|U .

Sa-gaṇa: U U| .

Ma-gaṇa: ||| .

Na-gaṇa: U U U .

In addition to these eight there are two further single-syllable units, *ga* and *la*.

Ga: one isolated long syllable (|).

La: one isolated short syllable (U).

A mnemonic for remembering all eight *gaṇas* is:

yamātārājabhānasalagām [यमाताराजभानसलगम्].

Now divide the mnemonic into its components:

yamātā — U|| = *ya-gaṇa*.

mātārā — ||| = *ma-gaṇa*.

tārāja — ||U = *ta-gaṇa*.

rājabhā — |U| = *ra-gaṇa*.

jabhāna — U|U = *ja-gaṇa*.

bhānasa — |U U = *bha-gaṇa*.

nasala — U U U = *na-gaṇa*.

salagām — U U⏑ = *sa-gaṇa*.

Correspondences between Bahr and Sanskrit Metre

Bahr-e-Mutaqārib: eight feet; *faʿūlun* (U⏑ –) repeated four times.

The Sanskrit varṇa-vṛtta Bhujaṅgaprayāta: the *ya-gaṇa* (U⏑ –) occurs four times in each line, giving twelve syllables. The first, fourth, seventh, and tenth syllables are short; all others are long. A caesura follows the sixth and final syllables.

Bahr-e-Mutaqārib: four feet; *faʿūlun* (U⏑ –) repeated twice.

The Sanskrit varṇa-vṛtta Somarājī: *ya-gaṇa* (U⏑ –) occurs twice, giving six syllables. The first and fourth are short and the remaining syllables long. A caesura follows the second and final syllables.

Quantitative form: twenty *mātrās* per line. The first, sixth, eleventh, and sixteenth *mātrās* are short.

Bahr-e-Mutadārik: eight feet; *fāʿilun* (– U⏑) repeated four times.

The Sanskrit varṇa-vṛtta Sragviṇī: the *ra-gaṇa* (– U⏑) occurs four times, giving twelve syllables. The second, fifth, eighth, and eleventh are short, and all others long. A caesura follows the sixth and final syllables.

Quantitative form: twenty *mātrās* per line. The third, eighth, thirteenth, and eighteenth *mātrās* are short.

Maḥdhūf: *bahr-e-Ramal musamman maḥdhūf*, consisting of *fāʿilātun* (– U⏑ –) three times followed by *fāʿilun* (– U⏑).

The quantitative metre Gītikā: twenty-six *mātrās* in each line. The third, tenth, seventeenth, and twenty-fourth are short.

Gītikā as a varṇa-vṛtta: a twenty-syllable pattern consisting of one *sa-gaṇa*, two *ja-gaṇas*, one *bha-gaṇa*, one *ra-gaṇa*, one *sa-gaṇa*, one *la-gaṇa*, and one *ga-gaṇa*. The third, fifth, eighth, tenth, thirteenth, fifteenth, eighteenth, and twentieth syllables are long; the rest short. Caesurae follow the fifth, twelfth, and final syllables.

Maḥdhūdh: *bahr-e-Mutadārik musamman maḥdhūdh* (all feet are modified): *fāʿilun* (– U⏑) three times followed by *fā* (–).

The Sanskrit varṇa-vṛtta Bālā: ten syllables per line; *ra-gaṇa* (ı U ı) three times, followed by one long syllable.

Quantitative form: seventeen *mātrās* per line. The third, eighth, and thirteenth *mātrās* are short, and the final unit is one long syllable, or alternatively two short syllables (U U).

The Early Forms of the Maithili Ghazal

"Even now, there remains inscribed upon my mind a remark by the respected Maithili critic Shri Ramanand Jha 'Raman'. He dismissed the present-day Maithili song and ghazal altogether, describing them as instruments of fame on the stage and monetary gain (see *Mithila Mihir*, February 1983). … What right does any critic have to make such an irresponsible statement? Is it because freedom of speech is a fundamental right under the Indian Constitution?" (Siyaram Jha "Saras", *Deepotsav*, 18 October 1990; preface to *Lokved aa Lal Qila*.)

In another preface to *Lokved aa Lal Qila*, Viyogi writes: "Even though it is based on the rules of prosody, the ghazal allows its poet the freedom to depart from the rules of calculation." (!)

Devshankar Naveen writes: "… Then came Dr Ramdev Jha's article. Among the absurdities of that essay were two things, one of them being that he began prescribing a count of *mātrās* for the lines of a ghazal, as though they were lines of metrical verse …"

Before the ghazals begin in *Lokved aa Lal Qila*, there is an essay; these prefatory writings offer no positive comment on the Maithili ghazal. They do, however, deliver a series of blows, as though a critic could be compelled, under threat of a stick, to declare: "These are Maithili ghazals —ghazals and nothing else."

It is true that a ghazal may be composed in several ways, in numerous *bahrs* and metres. But freedom from the rules of counting exists neither in quantitative metre nor in syllabic metre.

In the early composition of haiku in English, the correspondence between syllables and written letters could not be maintained: the 5/7/5 syllables could contain more letters than the Japanese pattern. I therefore advised that Maithili haiku should employ simple syllabic metre, without distinguishing short from long syllables. Sanskrit has seventeen-syllable metrical forms comprising seventeen syllabic units, such as *Śikhariṇī, Vaṃśapatrapatitam, Mandākrāntā, Hariṇī, Hāriṇī, Naradattakam, Kokilakam* and *Ābhārākrāntā*. Accordingly, I adopted seventeen counted units in a 5/7/5 arrangement for Maithili haiku. Mihir Jha, Ira Mallick, Umesh Mandal, Ramvilas Sahu and others are now using this practice.

With the *rubāī*, my advice was different: simple syllabic metre is not possible because its opening must be long–long–long or long–long–short. One must therefore use either a syllabic metre that observes the short–long sequence or a quantitative metre. In a *rubāī* quatrain, at least the first, second and fourth lines must rhyme, and a line should contain twenty or twenty-one *mātrās*. Since the four lines can be written in four different *bahrs* or metres, there is no need to narrow the rules further; what must be decided, however, is that the method of counting—syllabic or quantitative—should remain the same throughout the four lines.

For the ghazal, by contrast, one may use regulated syllabic, simple syllabic or quantitative metre; one must not mix two different systems within a single ghazal. You may call an unmetrical composition a ghazal—silencing the critic, as it were, with a stick in your hand—but it will not thereby become a ghazal. At an Urdu or Persian *mushāīra*, you would not even be admitted with it. Now that young ghazal poets such as Roshan Jha, Praveen Chaudhary "Prateek" and Ashish Anchinhar can revise their ghazals into simple syllabic metre after a single comment on the internet, why can the ghazal poets of the *Lal Qila* school not do the same? Mayanand Mishra continued the erroneous tradition under the name *geetal*, while Gangesh Gunjan perpetuated it by calling his work "something like a ghazal in Maithili". If Ajit Azad and other younger poets subsequently write ghazals without metre or *bahr*, I regard it as the adverse influence of Mayanand Mishra, Gangesh Gunjan and the non-ghazal poets of the *Lal Qila* school.

Lokved aa Lal Qila

Following the self-congratulatory prefaces, this collection presents ghazals by Kalanand Bhatt, Taranand Viyogi, Dr Devshankar Naveen, Narendra, Dr Mahendra, Ramesh, Ramchaitanya "Dheeraj", Ram Bharos Kapari "Bhramar", Rabindranath Thakur, Vibhuti Anand, Siyaram Jha "Saras" and Somdev.

Kalanand Bhatt

> "At dawn, we shall cause another, newer sun to rise." [Maithili: भोर आ नब हम दोसरउगायब सुरुज]
>
> "We shall build anew; we shall create a sun." [Maithili: करब नूतन निर्माण हम बनायब सुरुज]

By simple syllabic counting, the first line has seventeen units and the second eighteen. When even this elementary count differs, there is no need to go to the trouble of examining short and long syllables.

By quantitative counting, the first line has twenty-one *mātrās* and the second also twenty-one. Since the totals agree, let us examine the sequence of short and long syllables. The first line runs: long–short–long–short–short–short–short–long–short–short–short–long–short–short–short–short–short. Here two consecutive short syllables may be replaced by one long syllable, as we shall see in the second line. The second runs: short–short–short–long–short–short–short–long–short–short–short–short–long–short–short–short–short–short. But after the letter shown in bold in the original discussion, the sequence breaks down.

Taranand Viyogi

> "When pain crosses its limit, fire is born." [Maithili: दर्दजँहदकेँटपलजाए तँ आगिजनमै अछि]
>
> "When snow turns into embers, fire is born." [Maithili: बर्फअंगारबनलजाए तँ आगिजनमै अछि]

According to simple syllabic counting, the first line has nineteen units, the second eighteen. Since their counts differ even at this level, the labour of analysing short and long syllables is unnecessary.

By quantitative counting, both lines contain twenty-five *mātrās*. We may therefore proceed to the distribution of short and long syllables. In the first line the sequence is: long (before a conjunct consonant)–short–short–short–short–long–short–short–short–long–long–short–long–short–short–short–long–short–short. Two consecutive short syllables may be replaced by a long one, as can be tested against the second line. The latter, however, begins long (before a conjunct consonant)–short–long–long, and the sequence breaks at this point.

Devshankar Naveen

> "We shall arrest the wheel of time, here, between these very eyes." [Maithili: अँटालेबसमय-चक्र, सहजहिएहिआँखिबीच]
>
> "For the sake of a new dawn, we shall resolve upon revolution." [Maithili: नबकाप्रभातलेल, क्रान्तिकोनोठानिलेब]

In simple syllabic metre the first line contains nineteen units and the second sixteen. Since the elementary counts do not agree, there is no need to spend further effort on the short–long distribution.

By quantitative calculation both lines contain twenty-five *mātrās*. Let us therefore examine the syllabic succession. The first line has short–long–long–short–short–short–short–long–short–short–short–short–long–short–long–short–long–short. Two successive short syllables may stand in

place of one long syllable, a possibility to be compared with the second line. But in that second line, after short–short–long, the order breaks down at the letter shown in bold in the source.

Narendra

"Come out, dressed up and adorned." [Maithili: निकलूतँसजिकऽसजाकेँ]

"Beating the utensils, making them ring." [Maithili: बासनलीठोकिबजाकेँ]

Simple syllabic counting gives ten units in the first line and nine in the second. Since even these totals differ, there is no need to examine short and long syllables.

In quantitative metre the first line has thirteen *mātrās* and the second fourteen. Because the quantitative totals themselves disagree, further examination of short and long syllables is unnecessary.

Dr Mahendra

"A human being goes on, always, in order to keep moving." [Maithili: चलैछआदमी सदिखन चलैत रहबा लए]

"A human being lives on, always, in order to endure suffering." [Maithili: जीबैछआदमी सदिखनकलेससहबालए]

Simple syllabic counting gives eighteen units for each of these lines. But the second line of the third *sher* has only sixteen. In quantitative counting, moreover, the two lines cited above contain twenty-four and twenty-five units respectively.

Ramesh

"Whenever the sighing breath of the monsoon is felt—" [Maithili: जखन-जखनसाओनकओहासपड़ैए]

"Within my chest, the longing of the ghazal burns." [Maithili: हमर छातीमे गजलक लहास बरैए]

By simple syllabic counting, both lines contain sixteen units. But the first line of the second *sher* contains fifteen. In quantitative counting, too, the cited lines each have twenty-two *mātrās*. Yet the distribution of short and long syllables fails as early as the second word.

The same defects can be observed among the other ghazal writers in the collection.

In addition, some books—including Surendranath's *Ghazal Hamar Hathiyar Thik* ("The Ghazal Is My Weapon"), Siyaram Jha "Saras"'s

Thode Aagi Thode Pani ("A Little Fire, a Little Water"), Ramesh's *Nagpheni* ("Prickly Pear") and Taranand Viyogi's *Apan Yuddhak Sakshya* ("Testimony of One's Own War")—have been brought, as though with a stick in hand, into the post-Jayakant Mishra edition of the Sahitya Akademi's *Survey of Maithili Literature* as collections of ghazals. Some may find their way into the next edition of that literary history! Poems by Arvind Thakur are likewise appearing in periodicals under the designation "ghazal", extending the same tradition.

If these compositions are not ghazals, they are nonetheless verse, and they certainly deserve consideration as such. In this context, consider Rabindranath Thakur's *Lekhni Ek Rang Anek* ("One Pen, Many Colours"). The book appeared as a Maithili ghazal collection twenty-five years ago. His compositions, like those of Somdev and Bhramar, do not satisfy the definition espoused by the *Lal Qila* school. Even if they are not ghazals, their place in Maithili literature as poetry is secure. The same, however, cannot be said of the other purported collections of ghazals mentioned above.

> "One metre, one flute, one tune—for those who wish to hear." [Maithili: एकछन्द, एकबाँसुरी, एकधुनसुनयबालेऽ]
>
> "Here, take this ghazal, to hum today." [Maithili: लियौईएकगजल, आईगुनगुनयबालेऽ]

(Rabindranath Thakur, *Lekhni Ek Rang Anek*.)

The first misfortune of the Maithili ghazal appeared when the ghazal came to be associated exclusively with the Muslim religion, while that religion and its literature were treated as untouchable. The beginnings of the ghazal predate the coming of Islam; moreover, there are numerous similarities between the *Avesta* and Vedic Sanskrit. The second misfortune was Mayanand Mishra's declaration that ghazals could not be written in Maithili. Although his intention was different, others began presenting his statement in just that sense, especially because he himself composed ghazal-like poems under the name *geetal*. Then the online forum *Anchinhar Akhar* emerged in Maithili, and with it came many poets composing ghazals in proper *bahr*, that is, metre. The greatest misfortune, however, was that certain so-called Maithili *shāírs* rejected Ramdev Jha's arguments concerning *bahr* (see Devshankar Naveen's essay in *Lokved aa Lal Qila*). If we consider the contemporary scene, we can broadly distinguish two currents, which I have called two ages: the "Jeevan Age" and the "Anchinhar Age". Let us examine them in turn.

1. The Jeevan Age. I begin this age with Jeevan Jha, who is regarded as the father of the modern Maithili ghazal, although he wrote relatively few

ghazals. After him came Mayanand, Indu and Rabindranath Thakur, Saras, Ramesh, Narendra, Rajendra Vimal, Dhirendra Premarshi, Roshan Janakpuri, Arvind Thakur, Surendranath, Taranand Viyogi and others who wrote ghazals. A great many compositions by Ramlochan Thakur are also ghazals, although he himself arranged them like poems and songs; some nonetheless belong in the ghazal category. The chief characteristic of the ghazal in this "Jeevan Age" was its being *be-bahr*— without metre. Indeed, what place can *bahr* have when Surendranath himself becomes entangled in the intricacies of *qāfiya*, or rhyme? The age has other characteristics as well. If its disposition must be expressed in a single line, it would be: "It is a ghazal, this is a ghazal, and only this is a ghazal."

2. The Anchinhar Age. Let us now turn to the "Anchinhar Age". It began with the creation of *Anchinhar Akhar* (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com), the first Maithili blog devoted to ghazals and *sher-o-shāīrī* on the internet. After this forum, *Anchinhar Akhar*, I have named the period the "Anchinhar Age". Some of its characteristics are as follows.

Defining ghazal terminology and determining bahr. *The credit belongs to* Anchinhar Akhar*, which commissioned me to write* Maithili Ghazalshastra. *This became the first treatise to examine the ghazal in terms of the particular linguistic features of Maithili. Subsequently, Ashish Anchinhar reinforced that tradition through* Ghazalak Sankshipt Parichay* ("A Brief Introduction to the Ghazal"). It is a result of this work that the new generation of ghazal poets is composing within metre.

Training. *Anchinhar Akhar* established a tradition of instruction in the ghazal. From it emerged poets such as Sunil Kumar Jha, Deepnarayan "Vidyarthi", Roshan Jha, Praveen Chaudhary "Prateek", Tripurari Kumar Sharma, Vikas Jha "Ranjan", Sadre Alam Gauhar, Om Prakash Jha, Mihir Jha and Umesh Mandal.

The primacy of Maithili in the ghazal. Before the Anchinhar Age, ghazals were saturated with Urdu and Hindi vocabulary, and there was a prevailing belief that a ghazal could not be composed without such words. *Anchinhar Akhar* demolished this fallacy and publicly demonstrated the use of wholly Maithili vocabulary in the ghazal.

An award for ghazals. For the first time in Maithili literary history, *Anchinhar Akhar* announced a separate award for the ghazal. Its name was the "Ghazal Kamala–Kosi–Bagmati–Mahananda Award".

These four achievements yielded a final and most significant result: a rebuttal to the claim attributed to Mayanand Mishra that ghazals governed by *bahr* could not be composed in Maithili. Alongside simple syllabic, regulated syllabic and quantitative metres, *Anchinhar Akhar*

offered rules and examples for writing Maithili ghazals in Persian and Urdu *bahrs*, employing authentic Maithili vocabulary.

The ghazal, *rubāĭ, qiṭ́a*, haiku, senryū, tanka, haibun, *kuṇḍaliyā, dohā* and *rolā* are all established literary forms. By "established" I mean that the techniques of composition have become settled in the languages in which these forms were originally developed. If one ignores the rules of haiku, merely renaming the result a *kṣaṇikā* or brief lyric will not cure its defects as a haiku. We consider bringing the ghazal, *rubāĭ* or *qiṭ́a* from another language into Maithili precisely because it represents an extraordinary achievement in its original language, and because we hope that a Maithili inflection will produce another kind of excellence. The same applies to haiku, senryū, tanka and haibun. What matters, therefore, is importing a form with care, particularly when its theoretical foundations are already strong. Why should we import it haphazardly, sit idle for a hundred years, and wait for some separate theory of its Maithili character to emerge? In that time, we might develop an entirely new literary form instead.

It is true that, through transliteration alone, the rules of the Urdu ghazal can become the rules of a ghazal written in Hindi script. Even there, differences in spelling require the formulation of many subsidiary rules for *qāfiya*. Maithili, however, is a distinctly different language, so those rhyme rules cannot simply be imported. In the counting of syllables and *mātrās* for *bahr*, Hindi and Urdu may themselves occasionally require special rules because of variations in the spelling of particular words; such provisions cannot simply be transplanted into Maithili either. Does that mean we should abandon the rules governing *qāfiya* and the quantitative or syllabic counting of *bahr* altogether? Or relax them so completely that they become meaningless? Would the poet who uses a proper *bahr* and correct *qāfiya* then be branded a fundamentalist, or would it be the opponent of these conventions who deserves that description? If a composition without *qāfiya* and *bahr* is not called a ghazal, does that make it worthless? It is not a ghazal—or it may be called a ghazal of the Jeevan Age—but it remains a song or poem. Mere correctness of *qāfiya* and *bahr* certainly does not make a ghazal excellent, though it increases the likelihood of excellence many times over. Conversely, if a ghazal-like composition happens to be metrically sound but employs an incorrect *qāfiya*, is that alone proof of excellence? I would say instead that such a work may still be excellent, although its likelihood of achieving excellence is considerably diminished.

The ghazal, *rubāĭ, qiṭ́a*, haiku, senryū, tanka, haibun, *kuṇḍaliyā, dohā* and *rolā* are all rule-bound forms. What service is rendered to a language by converting them into non-poetry, prose poems or songs, when non-poetry, prose poetry and song are already established categories in their own right? A short poem may be a *kṣaṇikā*; it is not necessarily a haiku. No

particular difficulty arose in adapting the rules of *kuṇḍaliyā, dohā* and *rolā* to Maithili, because those rules could be imported directly. But for the ghazal, *rubāī, qiṭà*, haiku, senryū, tanka and haibun, the methods of counting syllables and *mātrās* cannot be carried straight over from Japanese or Urdu-Persian. Japanese writing, after all, is not alphabet-based; how, then, could one import its counting method unchanged? There is another way. Japanese also has Western-style and syllable-based representations of writing. Their syllabic representation can be compared with the counting system of Sanskrit syllabic metre, and this comparison has been used for haiku, senryū and tanka. Similarly, rules appropriate to the Maithili language were developed on a systematic basis for the ghazal, *qiṭà* and *rubāī*, allowing these forms to retain their original characteristics after entering Maithili. The subsequent quantitative and qualitative growth in Maithili ghazals and in their authors is there for the world to see.

The *wazn*, or metrical weight, of a line (*miṣra*) or its words can be determined in three ways: in simple syllabic metre, by counting syllabic units; in regulated syllabic metre, by counting the units together with their sequence of short and long values; and in quantitative metre, by attending to the short–long pattern and its *mātrās*. Anyone with some knowledge of singing understands that the number of words in one line of a ghazal may differ from the number in another, while the metrical weight must agree when measured by the chosen method. An independent, unmetrical (*āzād*, *be-bahr*) ghazal, on the other hand, offers no guarantee of equal weight across its words or lines. Ghazals composed in any of the three metrical systems preserve that equality. Much depends on the abilities of both the poet and the singer. For the poet, regulated syllabic metre is the most difficult, quantitative metre somewhat easier, and simple syllabic metre the easiest. For the singer, the order is reversed in part: regulated syllabic metre is easiest, quantitative metre harder, simple syllabic metre harder still, and the unmetrical *āzād* ghazal the most difficult of all.

Appendix 2

A Critical Theory of the Maithili Haiku, Haiku and Short Lyric

Haiku Rule 1

Now consider the first example.

Haiku Rule 2

Haiku Rule 3

Haiku Rule 4

Haiku Rule 5

Haiku Rule 6

A Haibun of Mine

"On foot, I crossed—" [Maithili: पएरे पार]

"the Kamala's current;" [Maithili: केने कमला धार,]

"today it is vast." [Maithili: आइ विशाल]

Maithili haiku. Sanskrit has seventeen-syllable metres such as *Śikhariṇī, Pṛthvī, Vaṃśapatrapatitam, Mandākrāntā, Hariṇī, Hāriṇī, Naradattakam, Kokilakam* and *Ābhārākrāntā*. These are all syllabic metres in which each line consists of seventeen counted units. Hence the seventeen syllables of the 5/7/5 sequence should be represented by seventeen syllabic units in Maithili haiku.

In Japan, the invocation of a deity in a *tanka* or *waka* prayer was arranged as 5/7/5/7/7. The *senryū* does not employ *kireji* and ranges beyond nature or the moon into humour and satire; nevertheless, its pattern, like that of haiku, consists of 5/7/5 syllables. Japanese syllables and Indian syllabic metres are comparable, so 5/7/5 syllables are treated as 5/7/5 counted units. Sanskrit seventeen-syllable metres include *Śikhariṇī, Vaṃśapatrapatitam, Mandākrāntā, Hariṇī, Hāriṇī, Naradattakam, Kokilakam* and *Ābhārākrāntā*. I have therefore adopted seventeen counted units for seventeen syllables, approaching the Japanese *onji*. A *kireji* is a word or marker at which a second thought begins; *kigo* is a season-related word. In Japanese, a *kireji* may occur in the middle or at the end of a line, including at the end of the third line when it carries the reader back to the beginning. Haiku joins two images of nature, and an accompanying form combining illustration and decoration, *haiga*, has also developed. The Japanese 5/7/5/7/7 *tanka* or *waka*, once used to invoke a deity, was later divided into a 5/7/5 section and a 7/7 section written by two different poets, taking a new form called *renga*. The collaborative practice of a single group later developed into *renku*. *Haibun* is a travel account combining brief descriptive prose and haiku verse. Bashō, a Japanese Buddhist monk and haiku poet, is identified here as the originator of haibun, through which he described his travels in Japan. To preserve the essential character

of haibun, I would set an upper limit of five prose paragraphs and an equivalent number of haiku, with a lower limit of one paragraph and one haiku. The haiku comes at the end of the prose paragraph as its culmination.

Note. The *senryū* does not use *kireji*, and its concerns extend beyond nature and the moon to humour and satire. Its formal arrangement, however, remains 5/7/5 syllables, like haiku. Japanese syllables are comparable with Indian syllabic metre; thus the 5/7/5 syllables are taken as 5/7/5 counted units. Among the seventeen-syllable Sanskrit metres with seventeen counted units are *Śikhariṇī, Vaṃśapatrapatitam, Mandākrāntā, Hariṇī, Hāriṇī, Naradattakam, Kokilakam* and *Ābhārākrāntā*. Accordingly, I have taken seventeen syllables to correspond to seventeen counted units, close to the Japanese *onji*. *Kireji* means a word or marker from which another thought begins, while *kigo* denotes a word associated with a season. The *kireji* appears in the middle or at the end of a Japanese line, including at the close of the third line when it returns the reader to the opening. As haiku combines two natural images, it is also associated with the illustrated art form *haiga*. The Japanese *tanka* or *waka* invocation was structured 5/7/5/7/7; later, two authors wrote the 5/7/5 and 7/7 portions separately, producing *renga*. This collaborative form was subsequently established as *renku*. A *haibun* combines descriptive prose with haiku (5/7/5) or tanka/waka (5/7/5/7/7). All these forms are available in a competitive creative environment on Videha's Facebook group and the Maithili Haiku blog.

Bashō was a Japanese Buddhist monk and haiku poet. Accounts of journeys through Japan and images of Mount Fuji recur frequently in his poetry.

Some of Bashō's haiku are presented here.

Haiku by Bashō

1. "By the banana tree / a sign of what I detest / a smiling leper."
2. "Even a horse / catches my eye / on this snowy morning."
3. "Another year has passed / a traveller's shade above my head / straw sandals on my feet."
4. "Come, let us go now / to enjoy the snow, before / I lag behind and fall."
5. "At the first chill of winter / even a monkey longs / for a little straw coat."
6. "The breeze from Mount Fuji / I carried in my fan / a gift for the people of Edo."

7. Bashō's final poem, composed while he lay on his deathbed: "Fallen ill in the midst of a journey / my dreams wander, grown dull / around a meadow of dry grass." (Free rendering and interpretation by Preeti Thakur.)

Appendix 3

Dohā, Rolā, Kuṇḍaliyā and the Principles of Metre

Dohā

The *dohā* is a quantitative metre. It has two lines and four sections (*caraṇas*). The first section contains thirteen *mātrās*, the second eleven, the third thirteen and the fourth eleven. The first and third sections must not begin with a *jagaṇa* (short–long–short, U|U), while the second and fourth must end with a long syllable followed by a short one.

Rolā

The *rolā* is also a quantitative metre. It comprises four lines and eight sections. The first section has eleven *mātrās*, the second thirteen, the third eleven, the fourth thirteen, and the same alternating pattern continues: the fifth has eleven and the sixth thirteen. The first section of every line ends either long–short or short–short–short. The second section of every line ends with any of the following: four short syllables; two long syllables; long–short–short (the *bhagaṇa*, |UU); or short–short–long (the *sagaṇa*, UU|). A *rolā* should not begin with short–long–short.

Kuṇḍaliyā

The *kuṇḍaliyā* is a linking or combination of *dohā* and *rolā*. First compose a *dohā*. Then repeat the final section of the *dohā*—the section of eleven *mātrās*—as the first section of the *rolā*, and continue with the *rolā*. One must ensure that the first word of the first section of the *dohā* and the final word of the last section of the *rolā* are identical. In other words, the *kuṇḍaliyā* begins and ends with the same word. Its fourth and fifth sections are also identical.

On Metre

Quantitative Counting

क् + अ = क (*k* + short *a* = *ka*).

क् + आ = का (*k* + long *ā* = *kā*).

क्ति = क् + त् + इ = ० + ० + १ = १.

क्ती = क् + त् + ई = ० + ० + २ = २.

क्ष = क् + ष = ० + १.

त्र = त् + र = ० + १.

ज्ञ = ज् + ञ = ० + १.

श्र = श् + र = ० + १.

स्र = स् + र = ० + १.

शृ = श् + ऋ = ० + १.

त्व = त् + व = ० + १.

त्त्व = त् + त् + व = ० + ० + १.

Short vowel + avagraha (ऽ) = १ + ०.

Short vowel + *candrabindu* (ॅ) = १ + ०.

Long vowel + *candrabindu* (ॅ) = २ + ०.

For example, हँसल = १ + १ + १.

साँस = २ + १.

जा कऽ = २ + १.

क् = ०.

क = क् + अ = ० + १.

U is the symbol for a short syllable.

I is the symbol for a long syllable.

One long syllable (I) is equivalent in quantity to two short syllables (U U).

Syllabic Counting

1. A letter bearing a *halant* (virāma) = 0.

2. A conjunct consonant = 1.

3. Each letter from अ to ह = 1.

Now consider the first example.

ई अरदराक मेघ नहि मानत रहत बरसि के = 1 + 5 + 2 + 2 + 3 + 3 + 3 + 1 = 20 *mātrās* ("These clouds of Ārdrā will not be deterred; they will go on raining").

Now consider the second example.

पश्चात् = 2 *mātrās* ("afterwards").

Now consider the third example.

आब = 2 *mātrās* ("now").

Now consider the fourth example.

स्क्रिप्ट = 2 *mātrās* ("script").

The seven principal Vedic metres are *Gāyatrī, Uṣṇik, Anuṣṭubh, Bṛhatī, Paṅkti, Triṣṭubh* and *Jagatī*. The other forms are their variants, including *aticchandas* and *vicchandas*. A metre is identified through its syllables. If the prescribed syllable count is not met, one or two syllables may be added to each *pāda*. The conjuncts with *ya* and *va* may be separated by inserting *i* and *u*, respectively. For instance:

वरेण्यम् = वरेणियम् (*vareṇyam* = *vareṇiyam*).

स्वः = सुवः (*svaḥ* = *suvaḥ*).

The syllable count can also be completed by splitting forms produced through *guṇa* and *vṛddhi* vowel changes.

ए = अ + इ (*e* = *a* + *i*).

ओ = अ + उ (*o* = *a* + *u*).

ऐ = अ/आ + ए (*ai* = *a*/*ā* + *e*).

औ = अ/आ + ओ (*au* = *a*/*ā* + *o*).

Simple syllabic metre does not take account of the distinction between short and long syllables. Regulated syllabic metre, however, can observe this distinction, for it began to be taken into consideration in later developments from Vedic syllabic metre. Consider the following example:

"I keep looking towards this cloud." [Maithili: तकैत रहैत छी ऐ मेघ दिस]

तकैत (*takait*): short + long + long; three syllabic units.

रहैत (*rahait*): short + long + short; three syllabic units.

छी (*chhī*): long; one syllabic unit.

ऐ (*ai*): long; one syllabic unit.

मेघ (*megh*): long + short; two syllabic units.

दिस (*diś*): short + short; two syllabic units.

In quantitative metre, the divisions known as *dvikal, trikal, catuṣkal, pañcakal* and *ṣaṭkal* may comprise anywhere from one syllabic unit (a single long syllable) to six units (six short syllables).

A *dvikal* contains a total of two *mātrās*: one long syllable or two short ones.

A *trikal* contains three *mātrās*, in any of three arrangements: short + long, long + short, or short + short + short.

A *catuṣkal* has four *mātrās*, a *pañcakal* five and a *ṣaṭkal* six.

In regulated syllabic metre there are eight types of three-syllable groups; they can be memorised through the mnemonic "यमाताराजसलगम्" (*yamātārājasalagam*).

The number of *pādas*, the placement of pauses (*yati*) and the provision of end-rhyme can be determined through syllabic or quantitative principles, allowing the poet to introduce variety in the sequence.

In syllabic metre, a group of three syllables is called a *gaṇa*. There are eight such groups:

Yagaṇa — UII (short–long–long).

Ragaṇa — IUI (long–short–long).

Tagaṇa — ||U (long–long–short).

Bhagaṇa — |UU (long–short–short).

Jagaṇa — U|U (short–long–short).

Sagaṇa — UU| (short–short–long).

Magaṇa — ||| (long–long–long).

Nagaṇa — UUU (short–short–short).

Besides these eight, there are two further units: *ga* and *la*.

The *ga-gaṇa* consists of a single long syllable (|).

The *la-gaṇa* consists of a single short syllable (U).

One mnemonic for remembering all eight groups is:

यमाताराजभानसलगम् (*yamātārājabhānasalagam*).

Let us divide this mnemonic into its components:

यमाता (*yamātā*) — U|| = *yagaṇa*.

मातारा (*mātārā*) — ||| = *magaṇa*.

ताराज (*tārāja*) — ||U = *tagaṇa*.

राजभा (*rājabhā*) — |U| = *ragaṇa*.

जभान (*jabhāna*) — U|U = *jagaṇa*.

भानस (*bhānasa*) — |UU = *bhagaṇa*.

नसल (*nasala*) — UUU = *nagaṇa*.

सलगम् (*salagam*) — UU| = *sagaṇa*.

10. Dramatic Literature, Parallel Maithili Drama and Theatre, and the Critical Theory of Dramatic Literature

Abstract

Ramkhelawan Mandal came from Katghatra village in Shivajinagar Block, Samastipur district; Bindeshwar Mandal was associated with him. People still remember the rising Maithili chorus and the song, "Mother, O mother, buy me a gun, for I shall become a soldier, mother." This troupe staged verse-dramas such as *Reshma–Chuhar*, *Sheet–Basant*, *Alha–Udal*, and *Natua Dayal*.

Keywords: drama · parallel tradition · plays · theatre · literary criticism · Maithili

4

A Parallel World of Maithili Theatre

Ramkhelawan Mandal came from Katghatra village in Shivajinagar Block, Samastipur district; Bindeshwar Mandal was associated with him. People still remember the rising Maithili chorus and the song, "Mother, O mother, buy me a gun, for I shall become a soldier, mother." The troupe presented verse-dramas including *Reshma–Chuhar*, *Sheet–Basant*, *Alha–Udal*, and *Natua Dayal*. The *Piya Desantar* (Maithili *Bidesiya*) troupe came from Purnia to places including Supaul, Saharsa, and Samastipur. The short play *Hasan–Husan* was also performed. The Ramraksha Chaudhary Natya Kala Parishad of Gayghat village, Kariyan Panchayat, post office Baidyanathpur, Samastipur district, took its production of *Vidyapati* as far as Gorakhpur. Its other productions included *Laungiya Merchai*, *Vidyapati*, *Chinik Laddu*, and *Basat*.

The performative element predominated in *Ankiya Nat*. *Kirtaniya* was in one sense a musical form, yet acting was central to it too. An *Ankiya* play began with the beating of the *mridanga*.

Every literary genre may be understood in two modes, *lokadharmi* and *natyadharmi*: the former relates to the everyday or vernacular, the latter to the classical or codified mode of expression. The vernacular mode is not simply "a play performed in a village," as some mistakenly assume; it signifies an avoidance of artificiality. Nor is it correct to suppose that village drama must necessarily be inferior. In *lokadharmi* performance, natural behaviour and ordinary human action predominate, bodily gestures are unadorned, and the cast, whether women or men, can be very large. In *natyadharmi* performance, speech may be expressed inwardly, through signs, or as an offstage voice. Dance, exceptional modes of dialogue, music set to *rāgas*, and divine figures alongside ordinary

characters belong to it. Inanimate things and animals may speak; an actor may perform double or triple roles; and music may intensify the emotional force of joy or grief.

Vedic narratives, the *Jātaka* stories, Aesop's fables, the *Panchatantra*, and the *Hitopadesha* developed alongside living traditions of popular balladry. Everywhere, the stories of privileged classes have existed beside folk narratives. Words such as *shithir*, *dulabh*, and *indar* in the *Rigveda* testify to the literary adoption of speech from the people. Although early forms can be traced from Ashokan inscriptions to the thirteenth century CE, the Prakrit languages discussed here in their more specific literary sense served, from approximately the first through the sixth centuries CE, two purposes. First, in Sanskrit literary drama, Shauraseni, Maharashtri, and Magadhi were used for common people and female characters; Vararuchi adds Paishachi as a fourth Prakrit. Examples occur in Kalidasa's *Abhijnanashakuntalam* and *Malavikagnimitram*, Shudraka's *Mrichchhakatikam*, Shriharsha's *Ratnavali*, Bhavabhuti's *Uttararāmacarita*, and Vishakhadatta's *Mudrarakshasa*. Second, these Prakrits subsequently became independent literary languages. They, too, were confined by grammatical rules and acquired increasingly ornate usages, while people turned to Apabhramsha and Avahattha; evidence also survives of Apabhramsha being used alongside Prakrit. Broadly, Shauraseni was employed in prose, Maharashtri in verse, and Magadhi–Ardhamagadhi in religious literature. Women and jesters in drama spoke Shauraseni but sang verse in Maharashtri, while characters designated by the hierarchy of the time as belonging to lower social orders spoke Magadhi.

Maithili Dramatic Literature and Its Critical Theory

Children and adults learn through drama, seeking to understand people and their surroundings. Plays once associated with temple festivals or royal palaces acquired an independent existence; drama also came to be employed in teaching other subjects. This made the participation of specialists from other fields necessary. Drama is both an autonomous subject and a means of application. The relationship between traditional and professional theatre, exemplary productions, stage design, and the performance of actual plays will together constitute a history of theatre. Before that can happen, however, an elementary knowledge of theatre and the habit of reading plays must be cultivated. As one reads, the work should also be analysed from the standpoint of stage management and acting. Engagement with drama and theatre can help children and adults become responsible, economically self-reliant, and active citizens.

The *Natyashastra* traces the origin of drama to the festival of Indra's banner. It identifies two dramatic subjects or representations: (1) the Churning of the Ocean of Nectar and (2) Shiva's Burning of Tripura.

Bharata had approximately ten forms of dramatic representation—the *dasharupaka*—incorporating dance, music, and acting; beyond these ten forms there were songs intended to be heard.

In the fifth century BCE, Panini mentioned Shilalin and Krishashva, who had compiled the *Natasutras*. *Nata* signifies an actor and *ranga* a theatre or stage. Bharata, Shilalin, and Krishashva are also given as synonymous designations associated with the *nata*.

Maithili drama, hitherto more strongly connected with dance and music and only marginally with painting and handicrafts, is now, through interventions by parallel theatre, establishing relations with physics, biology, history, geography, and literature. Those efforts should be strengthened.

Jyotirishwar's *Dhurttasamagama*, Vidyapati's *Gorakshavijaya*, *Kirtaniya* plays, *Ankiya Nat*, Munshi Raghunandan Das's *Mithila Natak*, Jeevan Jha's *Sundar Sanyog*, Ishanath Jha's *Chinik Laddu*, Govind Jha's *Basat*, Manipadma's *Tesar Kaniya*, Nachiketa's *Nayakak Nam Jeevan* and *Ek Chhal Raja*, Shreesh Ji's *Purushartha*, Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary's *Bhafait Chahak Jingi*, Rambharos Kapari 'Bhramar' 's *Mahishasur Murdabad*, Gangesh Gunjan's *Budhibadhiya*, and Nachiketa's *No Entry: Ma Pravish*: from the absurdity of Jyotirishwar's *Dhurttasamagama* to the postmodern absurdity of *No Entry: Ma Pravish*, a circle in the history of Maithili drama has been completed.

Among the characteristics of postmodernism are the emergence of several identities from a single individual; the inability to arrive at an event's complete meaning; and the uncertainty of when truth may become falsehood. Superficial thinking and a proliferation of such characters appear in postmodernism. There is neither optimism nor, properly speaking, pessimism. What remains is a kind of madness: the recognition that a thing can be thought of in many different ways. Faith is placed less in outcomes determined by causes, control, and planning than in those produced by chance. Republican and feminist perspectives, the red flag, and other ideological symbols become objects of playful ridicule; hence feminism and Marxism have opposed the postmodern outlook. Judgements of good and bad repeatedly lose their certainty. Everyone lives behind a mask.

A comparative study of Indian and Western dramatic theory demonstrates how much human thought may have in common despite geographical distance. Indian dramaturgy rests principally on Bharata's *Natyashastra* and Dhananjaya's *Dasharupaka*; Aristotle's *Poetics* is the authoritative text of Western dramatic theory. Bharata describes drama in terms of the imitation of action and emotion, while Dhananjaya defines it as the

imitation of a condition or state. In Indian poetics, imitation belongs to the actor's work, not the poet's. In the Western account, imitation is the poet's activity, while the actor receives little or no discussion. Aristotle gives special weight to plot. Tragedy comprises, besides plot, character, diction, thought, spectacle, and song. Bharata calls the plot associated with the hero the principal or *adhikarika* plot and the narrative that helps it the subsidiary or *prasangika* plot. Not every play, however, needs a subsidiary plot. In the postmodern *No Entry: Ma Pravish*, there is neither a conventionally principal nor a subsidiary plot: the protagonist is not an accepted or universal hero. No character is simply weak; all respond and rebound according to time and circumstance. In relation to its subject matter, a plot may be *prakhyata* (well known), *utpadya* (invented), or *mishra* (mixed). The first draws on history and the *Puranas*, the second on invention, and the third combines the two. Aristotle divides plots into simple and complex and relates narrative material to legend, invention, and history. His tragic character is distinguished and noble, a mixture of good and evil. Bharata calls a hero given to dance and music *dhiralalita*, one of peaceful disposition *dhiraprashanta*, one of heroic or warrior-like disposition *dhirodatta*, and a jealous or arrogant hero *dhiroddhata*. Indian theory describes five stages of action: beginning (*arambha*), effort (*prayatna*), prospect of attainment (*praptyasha*), certainty of attainment (*niyatapti*), and fruition (*phalagama*). At the stage of *praptyasha*, disappointment about the result may arise; at *niyatapti*, hope returns. Western dramatic theory speaks of exposition, development of the action, climax, denouement, and final outcome: the first three complicate the action and the last two resolve it. The five *arthaprakritis*, or plot-elements, are seed (*bija*), drop (*bindu*), banner (*pataka*), episode (*prakari*), and action or result (*karya*); *pataka* and *prakari* belong to subordinate narratives. The mature form of the seed is the completed action. Aristotle speaks of beginning, middle, and end. Consider now the *sandhis*, or dramatic junctures: *mukha* joins the seed with the beginning; *pratimukha* joins the drop with effort; *garbha* joins the banner with the prospect of attainment; *vimarsha* joins the episode with certainty of attainment; and *nirvahana* joins fruition with the completed action. Western theory seeks unity of place, time, and action. Abhinavagupta holds that a single act should not encompass more than a day's action, nor should two acts contain events extending beyond a year. Dryden opposed the three unities and defended the greater freedom of Shakespeare's plays.

Indian theorists defended the visual or performative character of drama, whereas Plato and Aristotle opposed it. In the sixteenth century, Ludovico Castelvetro defended the importance of performance; Ditetart also defended the visual aspect, while Dryden is said to defend the reading of plays. Dacier defended both readability and visibility. Abhinavagupta

likewise held that *rasa* is fully savoured after enactment, although reading can also yield an experience of *rasa*. Western stage practice is described as realistic and Indian theatrical practice as symbolic. Thus in *Abhijnanashakuntalam*, Kalidasa writes *iti sharasandhanam natayati* —"he acts as if fitting an arrow to the bow." Samuel Johnson wrote about comic and tragic elements in Shakespeare. Plato maintained that art cannot be good because it is false and unreal. His view should also be considered in the context of Athens' military weaknesses relative to Sparta. He opposed poetry and drama on the ground that memorising and repeating dialogue might attract people towards an artificial life. Aristotle, by contrast, does not see poetry as imitation alone: it also contains philosophy and universal truth. He associates tragedy and imitation with a release following pleasure, pity, and fear. Dialogue may take the form of an address or of conversation; conversation will contain less philosophical matter. In ancient Greece, poetry was understood as a message from the gods. Aristophanes distinguished good and bad poetry, while Theophrastus identified harsh, excellent, and grand kinds. Poetry and music are inseparable; European symphonies, in which many instruments play together in differing rhythms, introduced theoretical differences. Such matters also apply to the theatrical stage. A play must combine emotionally charged dialogue and action. Jeevan Jha is remembered in Maithili dramatic literature for the innovations he introduced in subject matter and craft, and for his effective combination of Sanskrit and Parsi elements.

Postmodernism. At many points it rejects the rationality and objectivity associated with modernity and criticises the supposed completeness of scientific knowledge. What we see need not be true; it may be a dream. Each person narrates truth and falsehood from a particular perspective. Postmodernism is often self-centred and humorous, while the distinction between good and bad repeatedly dissolves. People live behind masks, the complete meaning of events eludes them, and there is no certainty about when truth may become untruth. Postmodern theatre is crowded with superficial thought and such characters; it is neither optimistic nor wholly pessimistic. What persists is a kind of madness and the conviction that one thing admits many interpretations. Outcomes are attributed less to causal design, control, and planning than to chance. Republican and feminist viewpoints, the red flag, and other ideological signs appear as objects of symbolic humour. Spectators recognise themselves in the many problems raised within the plot. The conflicts in these plays are the conflicts that people confront repeatedly in their own lives.

Bharata's *Natyashastra*

The Sangeet Natak Akademi organised its first National Theatre Festival in 1956, opening with Kalidasa's Sanskrit *Abhijnanashakuntalam*, presented by the Goa Brahman Sabha. Stage settings and costumes should be studied with reference to the period in which a play is set. Several celebrated Parsi-theatre productions, including *Inder Sabha*, *Alam Ara*, and *Khonne Nahak* (based on Shakespeare's *Hamlet*), were also made into films.

There are two kinds of drama, *lokadharmi* and *natyadharmi*: the former is vernacular, the latter a classical mode of expression. *Natyadharmi* practice is founded upon *lokadharmi*. Refine the vernacular mode, and it becomes the classical mode.

Lokadharmi has two varieties: *chittavrttyarpika*, concerned with inner happiness and sorrow, and *bahyavastvanukarini*, imitating external objects such as ponds and lotus pools. *Natyadharmi* likewise has two varieties: *kaishiki shobha*, displaying bodily grace and the splendour of song, dance, and music; and *amshopajivani*, the symbolic presentation of the Pushpaka aerial chariot, hills, forests, and the like. Acting as a whole is divided into *angika* (bodily), *vachika* (verbal), *sattvika* (expressing inward feeling), and *aharya* (costume, stage setting, and other visible means). *Angika* employs the body, face, and gestures; *vachika* employs the speech of gods, kings, non-Aryan figures, animals, and birds. The *sattvika* modes include *stambha* (immobility under joy, fear, or sorrow); *sveda* (sweating or associated expressions, such as clutching the head to suppress an overwhelming feeling); *romancha* (horripilation); *svarabhanga* (a broken or heavy voice, with tears in the eyes); *vepathu* (trembling); *vaivarnya* (pallor); *ashru* (tears falling repeatedly); and *pralaya* (collapse or a state represented by lying as a corpse). *Aharya* includes *pusta* (stage constructions of elephants, tigers, mountains, and similar objects), *alankara* (dress and ornaments), *angarachana* (colour, moustaches, costume, and hair), and *sanjiva* (the representation of living beings—snakes without legs, two-legged humans and birds, and four-legged animals). Two further forms are *samanya abhinaya* (general acting, discussed in Chapter 22 of the *Natyashastra*) and *chitrabhinaya* (pictorial acting, also attributed here to Chapter 22). After the fourfold classification, general acting is described as a synthesis of bodily, verbal, and emotional acting, with *sattvika* predominating. Pictorial acting is associated with *angika*: bodily movements evoke the image of mountains, ponds, birds, and other objects. For the staging and direction of plays, Kalidasa's *Abhijnanashakuntalam* is essential reading. Stage directions such as *rathavegam nirupya* ("indicating the speed of the chariot"), *suta pashyainam vyapadyamanam* ("charioteer, see him being struck down"),

iti sharasandhanam natayati ("acts the fitting of an arrow"), *vrikshasechanam rupayati* ("represents watering a tree"), *kalasham avarjayati* ("tilts or empties a water-pot"), *mukham asyah samunnamayitum icchati* ("wishes to raise her face"), *Shakuntala pariharati natyena* ("Shakuntala resists by acting"), and *natyena prasadhayatah* ("they adorn her through acting") mean that these actions are suggested through performance rather than literally carried out. In the last example, Anasuya and Priyamvada mime the adornment of their friend Shakuntala, either because the cosmetics are unavailable or because the scene cannot accommodate the time required. Similarly, the other directions call for miming irrigation, the emptying of the pot, fast travel by chariot, drawing the bow, seeing the threatened deer, Dushyanta's attempt to lift Shakuntala's face, and her response in resisting him.

Bharata's stage. Its elements include a rear curtain; the *nepathya* or backstage dressing room; entrance and exit doors; special curtains concealing these entrances and exits; the *vedika*, a platform in the middle of the stage for the musicians; the *rangashirsha*, an area towards the rear; the *mattavarani*, spaces for acting near the two front corners; and the *rangapitha*, the principal performance area at the front.

Evaluating acting: theatrical criticism. In Chapter 27 Bharata identifies success as the aim of performance: a staging should achieve its full effect. When an audience exclaims, "Yes!", "Bravo!", or "What a tragic ending!", its members are *sahridaya*, responsive spectators in Bharata's terminology, participating imaginatively in the playwright's and the characters' experience. Dramatic competitions were held, and adjudicators awarded prizes. Bharata established criteria for assigning positive and negative marks. Faults of acting and performance include: (1) lack of concentration; (2) speaking another character's dialogue; (3) a personality unsuited to the role; (4) failures of memory; (5) assuming a manner inconsistent with one's part; (6) dropping a prop or object; (7) stumbling in speech; (8) grammatical and other errors; (9) inadequate execution; (10) musical errors; (11) faults in verbal delivery; (12) lack of foresight; (13) inadequate materials; (14) deficient make-up; (15) a playwright's or director's insertion of a passage from another play; and (16) language that is neither simple nor clear. Judges must represent different fields and remain impartial. They should assess the whole effect of a play, its continuity, the relative proportions of its qualities, and the representation of feeling. The stage manager—the *sutradhara*—and the assistant, the *pariparshvaka*, must understand all aspects of drama. The leading actress should be skilled in music and acting; the leading actor or hero brings the performance to success through his abilities. Actors should be cast according to their physical and verbal characteristics: a person of small stature might be assigned the part of a valiant speaker, a thin and frail person the role of a

servant, and an accomplished talker that of a jester. The director of the musical ensemble, the *taurika*, must command every aspect of music in order to direct the instrumentalists or *kushilavas*.

Maithili drama. Much has been said about the continuity between ancient and modern Maithili and other theatrical traditions. The fact remains, however, that nowhere in India or Nepal is there a theatrical space or a scheme of dramatic representation preserved exactly as described in Bharata's *Natyashastra*. Its restoration is a formidable task, but parallel theatre has attempted it. A shortened production of Kalidasa's drama prepared without adequate knowledge can generate serious controversy. Maithili theatre has the possibility of staging *uparupakas* through an understanding of folk theatre based on the *Natyashastra*. The Videha Theatre Festival of 2012, directed by Bechan Thakur, was an attempt in this direction.

Towards a Critical Theory of Maithili Drama and Theatre

Prose narratives are classified by their length as short-short stories, stories, and novels. In that context, the verse transformation of a novel—or, in some instances, of drama—may be called an epic. If one goes back to the Rigvedic tradition, an epic should be called a *gita-prabandha*, a composition in song. The exchanges between Lakshmana and Parashurama, Manthara and Kaikeyi, or Ravana and Angada offer engaging verse resembling dramatic dialogue. Stories, tales, narratives, novels, and, to a degree, plays and one-act plays are listened to, recited, read, or performed for entertainment. They may have a purpose, or they may contain purposelessness and absurdity: even apparently purposeless literature affords enjoyment amid the bustle of life.

A one-act play is an *ekanki*; a play in the broader sense is a *natak*. By reducing the scope for dialogue or placing dialogue before the dramatic presentation, a short-short story or story may be made more forceful; otherwise it can turn into a one-act or full-length play. For Bharata, a drama produces *rasa* through its effect. What is a drama for? For the performance of *rasa*, and also for its production. How does *rasa* arise? Through its determinants (*vibhava*), its consequent expressions (*anubhava*), and the accompanying or transitory states (*vyabhichari bhava*). A durable emotion (*sthayi-bhava*), intensified and brought to maturity, becomes *rasa*, which we can savour.

From a translator's standpoint, drama is the most difficult form of creative literature, followed by poetry and then narrative fiction. In a play one must identify the background and implicit meanings, while also understanding the psychology of the characters. Kalidasa's Sanskrit plays employed Apabhramsha alongside Sanskrit for characters outside the elite; the

language of the *Charyapadas* was likewise an Apabhramsha mixed with Magadhi.

There is an urgent need to ensure that casteist expressions are not employed in Maithili drama and theatre to insult anyone. Old folktales or narratives can be made appropriate to a new context only when the playwright has the necessary ability. Drama and theatre could become instruments for overcoming caste divisions and producing harmony, but how can they do so unless people see the productions? This requires talented playwrights and directors capable of presenting complex issues intelligibly. Neither the subject alone nor entertainment alone is a measure of excellence. Maithili has already experienced the consequences of the games played by casteist theatre in the name of entertainment. A balance must be struck among the problem, its resolution, entertainment, and artistic form.

Modern Maithili Drama: Theatre Organisations and Directors

Dhurttasamagama. Written by Jyotirishwar Thakur in the thirteenth century, this work survives in Sanskrit and Maithili. Maithili songs are incorporated even into Jyotirishwar's Sanskrit* Dhurttasamagama. *It belongs to the genre of* prahasana*, or farce. Most Maithili plays and dramatic pieces of the period drew on the lives of Krishna or his descendants, often using abduction or* svayamvara *as their narrative basis. The principal figures of* Dhurttasamagama*, by contrast, are an ascetic and his disciple. Every character is a rogue of the highest order, making the title —"A Gathering of Rogues"—entirely appropriate. As the farce is also related to music, its inclusion of Maithili songs is fitting. The main characters are the* sutradhara*, an actress, the graduate disciple (*Snataka*), Vishwanagar, Mritangara, Suratpriya, Anangasenā, Asajjati Mishra, Bandhuvanchaka, Mulanashaka, and a townsman. The stage manager first praises the Karnata ruler Narasimhadeva, and then Jyotirishwar himself. There is an essentially modern absurdity in the play, and its flexibility gives it the character of folk theatre. Vishwanagar is celibate for want of a woman. He and his disciple Snataka visit the house of Mritangara Thakur in search of alms, but are turned away on the pretext of ritual impurity following a death or birth. They then go to Suratpriya's house. A quarrel breaks out between the master and the disciple over a courtesan named Anangasenā. They take her to Asajjati Mishra, a lecher who regards gambling and sexual pleasure as the essence of the world. "Who is the plaintiff and who the defendant?" asks Mishra. Snataka replies: "I am the plaintiff for presenting the complaint, and the ascetic is the defendant because he will pay the fee." Vishwanagar offers Snataka's bundle of cannabis as his payment. The jester whispers into Asajjati Mishra's ear, praising Anangasenā's sexuality. Asajjati Mishra places Anangasenā

between the two rivals and pronounces judgement in his own favour. The jester then whispers to her: "This ascetic is poor, Snataka is a wastrel, and Mishra is a fool. Stay with me instead." Looking around at all four, Anangasenā exclaims, "This truly has become a gathering of rogues!" Vishwanagar and Snataka once more head towards Suratpriya's house. Meanwhile, Mulanashaka the barber asks Anangasenā for a year's earnings or payment. She sends him to Asajjati Mishra. Assuming that Mishra is Anangasenā's husband, Mulanashaka accepts cannabis as his fee, binds him, and gives him such a violent massage that he faints. Believing him dead, the barber runs away. The jester arrives, unties Mishra, and asks, "I have saved your life; is there anything else you would like me to do?" Asajjati replies: "Through deception I have consumed an entire country; through roguery I obtained this beloved woman, and I have also gained an obedient disciple like you. Nothing could please me more. Still, may happiness and peace prevail everywhere."

Gorakshavijaya, by Vidyapati Thakur.* *Before this play—with the exception of* Dhurttasamagama*—dramas centred on Krishna were customary. In this respect* Gorakshavijaya* may also be called a revolutionary play. Its plot is constructed around Gorakhnath, the yogi associated with the Nath or Goraksha order. Gorakhnath's teacher Matsyendranath has abandoned yoga, become king of Kadalipur, and given himself over to pleasure with eighteen queens. A gatekeeper prevents Goraksha and Kananipada from entering. The minister orders a proclamation that no yogi is to be admitted anywhere, and the queens are instructed to keep the king enchanted. Goraksha and Kananipada disguise themselves as performers and present a captivating dance before the king. Meanwhile, the king's only son, Bodhnath, dies while playing. The king suspects the performers and orders them killed. They restore the child to life. When the king asks who they are, they remind him of everything concerning his former life: he is a yogi, not a man of sensual indulgence. The characters include Mahamati, the king's minister, and Mahadevi, Matsyendranath's senior queen. Matsyendranath, king of Kadalipur, had been a yogi in his previous life. At the end, he declares: "May every disciple be like Goraksha, and every woman like Mahadevi."

Jeevan Jha

Jeevan Jha wrote four plays: *Sundar Sanyog* (1904), *Maithili Sattak* (1906), *Narmada Sagar Sattak* (1906), and *Samavati Punarjanma* (1908). Several performances of these plays took place before 1920 at the Samaveda School in Kashi; *Sundar Sanyog* was also published there. Other performances of *Sundar Sanyog* include the following. In 1974, during Durga Puja, it was staged on the premises of Lakshminarayan High School at Malimodtar, near the Hasanpur sugar mill, directed by Shri Kalikant Jha "Booch"; the

chief guest was Shri Fazlur Rahman Hashmi. The organisers included Devnandan Pathak, chief engineer, and Akeshnandan Pathak, an auditor also called Tika Babu, and the inauguration was by Udit Rai, the *mukhiya*. It was performed in 1976 at Kariyan, Samastipur, under the direction of Kamdev Pathak. In 1981 it was staged at Pandit Tola, Tabhka, near Dalsinghsarai, coordinated by Dr Umendra Jha "Vimal", a former pro-vice-chancellor of Kameshwar Singh Sanskrit University. Mahamahopadhyaya Chitradhar Mishra, officiant at the Shankar temple within Darbhanga Fort, whose pupils included Mahamahopadhyaya Umesh Mishra and Mahamahopadhyaya Ganganath Jha. Another performance is recorded in 1983 at Mau Bajitpur, near Vidyapatinagar.

These plays by Jeevan Jha, imbued with elements of the Sanskrit tradition and Parsi theatre, were performed at many other places as well.

It is propaganda by casteist theatre to claim that Malangiya Ji's organisation would give these plays their first performance; these plays had already been staged repeatedly before Malangiya Ji was born. There is concern that the organisation's rewriting of *Sundar Sanyog* might itself make the work casteist by combining what he describes as Malangiya's supposedly invented *raar*-speaking Maithili, Brahminical-feudal Maithili, and a corrupted Hindi of the "khaderan ki madar" or "bujhta hai ki nahin" variety. This false claim about a premiere is being circulated to secure government funding for Malangiya's theatre.

Ishanath Jha

Ugana. These plays are staged on Mahashivaratri at the Gaurishankar shrine in Jamthuri. Vidyapati was a devotee of Shiva. To hear his songs of devotion, or* nachari*, Mahadeva entered his house in the guise of a servant named Ugana. Once, when Vidyapati was travelling with Ugana, he became thirsty. Ugana drew water from the Ganga flowing through his matted hair and gave it to Vidyapati. Recognising the taste of Ganga water and seeing Ugana's wet hair, Vidyapati understood everything. Ugana revealed his true form but warned him not to tell anyone or he would vanish. Parvati then devised a stratagem. Vidyapati's wife sent Ugana to fetch* bel* leaves and, when he was late, raised a broom against him. Vidyapati disclosed the secret, and Ugana disappeared.

Chinik Laddu (*Sugar Laddus*).** After the death of Sudhakant and Premkant's father, their maternal uncle Dharmanand looks after them as a trustee. When the brothers grow capable of managing their affairs, he hands responsibility to Sudhakant and leaves. Sudhakant's clerk Batua Das, aided by Premkant's wife Chandika and the maid Chhulahi, engineers a partition of the estate. Sudhakant even gives his own share to Premkant. He, his wife Sushila, and their son Sukumar are expelled from the house.

Sudhakant dies of tuberculosis. Association with Batua Das also impoverishes Premkant. Dharmanand, who has no children, bequeaths his estate to Sukumar. Premkant and Batua Das attempt to murder Sukumar by sending him a gift of sugar laddus mixed with poison. Instead, Batua Das dies from them, and the plot is exposed.

Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"

Nayakak Nam Jeevan (*The Hero's Name Is Life*).** Naval is a man of new ideas; Shaktiray is wealthy and depraved. Shaktiray accuses his associate Vinay of theft and arranges the kidnapping and rape of Vinay's daughter. Vinay takes his own life. Naval and his friends Prakash and Deepak reveal the truth. The young woman Naval loves dies by suicide as a consequence of the assault, and Naval suffers a mental breakdown.

Ek Chhal Raja (*Once There Was a King*).** A king, Abhiman Kumar Dev, wastes his days on alcohol and courtesans. He has only one daughter, Mohini, whose marriage cannot take place because of financial hardship. The play proceeds through the roles of the clerk Biranchi, the servant Chatur Lal, and the king's religiously observant wife. Mohini and a teacher named Shubhankar fall in love.

No Entry: Ma Pravish. This postmodern drama returns, in its absurdity, to Jyotirishwar's* Dhurttasamagama*. The dead arrive at what appears to be the gate of heaven or hell and recount their stories. Eventually it is revealed that Chitragupta and Dharmaraja are impostors, and the gate is locked: "No Entry."

Govind Jha

*Basat.** Krishnakant refuses to marry Pushpa, the young woman selected by his father; he wants an educated wife and falls in love with Lily. His father leaves home. Pushpa also leaves and devotes herself to women's awakening. Unable to find his father, Krishnakant abandons Lily and attempts to die beneath a train. People from an ashram save him. At the ashram he meets his father and Pushpa, while Lily, who has also lost her mental balance, arrives there.

Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary

Bhafait Chahak Jingi (*Life in Steaming Tea*).** Mahesh is unemployed and opens a tea stall; he is also a poet. Chandrama, the wife of the engineer Umanath, sees him at the stall. When Mahesh is called away to recite poetry, Chandrama begins selling tea. Umanath becomes angry. Mahesh's friend Sarita, the wife of an Indian Administrative Service officer, arrives.

*Letait Anchar.** Dinanath's only daughter, Mamata, has been abandoned by her husband on account of her father's poverty. Later, when Dinanath

attempts to secure a dowry at the wedding of his son Modnath, the son restrains him.

II. Maithili Haiku, Haikū, and Kshanika

Abstract

Haiku is a Japanese poetic form concerned with beauty and feeling. It was established as an independent poetic form in Japan by the poet Matsuo Bashō (1644–1694). Its composition demands profound experience. Bashō is said to have declared that a person who writes three to five haiku in a lifetime is a haiku poet, while one who writes ten is a great poet.

Keywords: haiku · haikū · kshanika · critical theory · Maithili

Haiku is a Japanese poetic form concerned with beauty and feeling. It was established as an independent poetic form in Japan by the poet Matsuo Bashō (1644–1694). Its composition demands profound experience. Bashō is said to have declared that a person who writes three to five haiku in a lifetime is a haiku poet, while one who writes ten is a great poet. In India, Rabindranath Tagore was the first to make literal translations of two haiku by Bashō, after returning from Japan in 1919.

The Maithili language and the Indian script systems derived from Sanskrit are exceptionally suitable for haiku. With the exception of Tamil, the scripts of southern India and of northern, western, and eastern India, including Devanagari, share a pattern of vowels and the five consonantal series—*ka*, *cha*, *ṭa*, *ta*, and *pa*—in which pronunciation follows spelling. The short vowel *i* appears to be an exception in Devanagari: it is written before the consonant but pronounced after it. In Maithili, however, even this is no exception: अछि (*achhi*) is pronounced as *a* followed by a short *i* and *chh*, or *a-i-chh*. Take another example: राति (*rāti*) may be separated as *rā-i-ta*. This proves that Maithili is the best language for haiku. Consider another illustration. Is *sandhi* a peculiarity of Sanskrit? Does English have no such joining of sounds? What, then, is "I'm going towards the end," when written as "I am going towards the end"? Panini formulated the rules of *sandhi* on the basis of phonetics. In English, the joining is not consistently reflected in conventional writing—although "I am" may be rendered phonetically as "I'm"—but it occurs in speech. In Maithili, too, case-endings are, wherever possible, written and pronounced together with their words.

In Japan, invocatory *tanka* or *waka* prayers followed a 5–7–5–7–7 pattern. Later, two authors composed the 5–7–5 and 7–7 portions separately, producing a new form called *renga*. Courtly *renga* assumed a solemn air; a less solemn variety belonged to the mercantile classes. Bashō composed the latter. A *renga* began with a *hokku*, while *haikai* could designate another of its verses. Masaoka Shiki proclaimed the end of *renga* in the early

nineteenth century and consolidated *hokku* and *haikai* into the form called *haiku*. Bashō, however, had already given that form an independent identity.

Haiku Rule 1

Write a haiku in seventeen syllabic units. It is written in three lines, arranged 5–7–5. Count the syllabic units as in *varnika chhand*, or syllabic metre.

In counting syllabic metre, reckon a conjunct consonant as one unit. Do not count a *halant*, a supplementary vowel mark or *bikari*, or the vowel signs for *i*, *ā*, and the like separately.

Literature has two modes, prose and verse. A composition governed by metre is verse; otherwise it is prose. *Chhand*, or metre, denotes a composition that gives pleasure.

There are two kinds of metre: quantitative (*matrika*) and syllabic (*varnika*). The Vedas employ syllabic metres.

Consider syllabic metre. Only the number of syllabic units is counted. A consonant marked with *halant* is not separately counted. A syllable with the signs for *e*, *u*, or other vowels counts as one, just as a conjunct consonant does. Letters from *a* through *ha* likewise count as one each. No unit is given a double value. Remember principally three points:

1. A consonant with *halant*: 0. 2. A conjunct syllable: 1. 3. Each letter from *a* to *ha*: 1.

Now examine the first example:

ई अरदराक मेघ नहि मानत रहत बरसि के — "These clouds of Ardra will not stop raining"; count: 1 + 5 + 2 + 2 + 3 + 3 + 1 = 17 units.

Now the second example: पश्चात् (*pashchāt*) = 2 units. Consider a third example:

आब (*āb*, "now") = 2 units. And the fourth: स्क्रिप्ट (*script*) = 2 units.

Haiku Rule 2

Satire is not the subject of haiku; its subject is the season. In Japan, the form employed for satire and human frailty is called *senryū*, and it has neither the grammatical cutting pause, *kireji*, nor the seasonal word, *kigo*.

Haiku Rule 3

In Japanese haiku a *kireji*, or grammatical cutting pause, is placed after the first five or the second seven sound units.

Haiku Rule 4

Japanese has no such distinction of gender and number. It is therefore appropriate to maintain the same number-form in Maithili as well.

Haiku Rule 5

In Japanese, the 5–7–5 sound units may be presented in a single line. In Maithili, however, use three lines for the three sound-groups of 5, 7, and 5. In recitation, apart from the *kireji* pause—marked here by a semicolon—it is appropriate to read the poem in a single breath.

Haiku Rule 6

A *haibun* is a travel account combining brief descriptive prose with haiku verse. Bashō, a Japanese Buddhist monk and haiku poet, is presented as its initiator; he recorded his travels through Japan in haibun. Let us set an upper limit of five paragraphs and as many haiku, so that the spirit of haibun may be preserved. A lower limit of one prose paragraph and one haiku is naturally possible. The haiku comes at the close of the prose paragraph as its culminating moment.

A Haibun of My Own

Ahead is the combined railway and road bridge at Jhanjharpur. The year is 1987. The waters of the Kamala–Balan surge and roar: a scene of flooding. I return towards the embankment. Before me, at one point, water bursts forth with a turbulent noise. Then the stream begins cutting away the earth at that place. The flow grows stronger; the flood comes. I turn back towards the village. Supplies are being dropped from a helicopter. Where floodwater has spread, very little dry, raised ground remains on which to drop supplies. Crowds gather at those few places. At the sight of the helicopter there is a commotion. An accident is feared. The helicopter does not drop food there. It moves farther on and drops supplies where, in ordinary times, lack of water brings drought but where the flood has now provided irrigation. Here there is no fear of an accident. I saw all this with my own eyes, in 1987.

Once crossed on foot—
the current of the Kamala,
immense today.

English haiku by Mrs Jyoti Jha Chaudhary, accompanied by my Maithili translations.

(1) Illusion of eye
Colourful appearance of
Rainbow in the sky
An illusion of the eye— (आँखिक भ्रम)

a many-coloured appearance, (आभास वर्णमय)

rainbow in the sky. (पनिसोखा द्यौ)

(2) Rainbow declares
Beginning of bright days and
End of rainy ones
The rainbow— (पनिसोखाक)

bright days are coming; (शुभ्र दिन आबह)

the rains depart. (खिचाहनि जा)

(3) Filled with smoky fog
The wood seems to be burning
Thou' it is winter
Smoky mist— (धुँआ कुहेस)

as though the wood were burning; (जेना जड़ैत काठ)

it is winter. (अछि ई जाड़)

(4) The words sound so sweet
imitated by parrots
Like baby babbles
Sweetly resonant— (गुञ्ज मधुर)

parrots imitating, (सुग्गाक अभिनय)

a child's lisping voice. (तोतराइत स्वर)

(5) The sky is bright
The wind has cleared the clouds
Some still needs force
The sky is bright— (अकाश श्वेत)

the wind drives away the clouds; (वायु टारैत मेघ)

a little more force. (कनेक बल)

12. Dohā, Rolā, and Kuṇḍaliyā

Abstract

Kuṇḍalī. "*Chhattā ghurchhā pallausā*, darkness fell in daylight. When the day had passed, I returned home; time had become terrifying. Time had become terrifying; every limb shudders. Who will hear the question? Speech summons the wild uproar. Airavata is distressed; where has the voice disappeared? Returning in the form of Time, it enters the midst of the whirling hive." A *dohā* contains two lines and four metrical segments: the first has 13 *mātrās*, the second 11, the third 13, and the fourth 11.

Keywords: *dohā* · *rolā* · *kuṇḍaliyā* · critical theory · Maithili

Kuṇḍalī

छत्ता घुरछा पल्लौसँ, भेल दिने अन्हार।

दिन बितलापर घर घुरी, काल भेल विकराल॥

काल भेल विकराल, पोरे-पोर सिहरैए।

सुनत केओ सवाल, बोल बगहा लगबैए।

ऐरावत बेहाल, बोल कतऽ भेल निपत्ता।

घुरियाए बनि काल, पैसि बिच घोरन छत्ता।

"The whirling *chhattā* and *pallau* darkened the day. / When the day ended, I returned home; Time turned dreadful. / Time turned dreadful; each limb trembles. / Who will hear the question? The voice brings a wild tumult. / Airavata is distraught; where has the voice gone? / Time circles back, entering the swirling *chhattā*."

Dohā

The *dohā* is a quantitative metre. It has two lines and four segments. The first segment contains 13 *mātrās*, the second 11, the third 13, and the fourth 11. The first and third segments must not begin with a *jagaṇa* (U ⏑ U), and the second and fourth segments end with a long syllable followed by a short one.

Rolā

The *rolā* is also a quantitative metre. It consists of four lines and eight segments. The first segment has 11 *mātrās*, the second 13, the third 11, the fourth 13, the fifth 11, and the sixth 13; the pattern continues in alternation through the eighth. The first segment of each line ends in long–short, or in three short syllables. The second segment of each line ends in four short syllables, two long syllables, a long followed by two shorts (*bhagaṇa*: ⏑ U

U), or two shorts followed by a long (*sagaṇa*: U U ।). Do not begin a *rolā* with short–long–short.

Kuṇḍaliyā

The *kuṇḍaliyā* is a coupling or mixture of *dohā* and *rolā*. First compose a *dohā*. Then repeat its final segment—the segment with ११ *mātrās*—as the opening segment of a *rolā*, and continue with the rest of the *rolā*. Take care that the opening word of the first segment of the *dohā* is the same as the final word of the concluding segment of the *rolā*. Thus the first and last words of a *kuṇḍaliyā* are identical. Its fourth and fifth segments are identical too.

On Metre

Literature has two forms, prose and verse. A composition bound by metre is verse; otherwise it is prose. *Chhand*, or metre, signifies a composition that provides pleasure.

Metres are of two kinds: quantitative (*matrika*) and syllabic (*varnika*).

Quantitative Counting

Let us consider the pronunciation conventions of Maithili and the distinction between short and long syllables.

Become acquainted with the *guru* and *laghu* syllables used in classical prosody.

Of the thirteen vowel letters, *a, i, u, ṛ,* and *ḷ* are short, while *ā, ī, ū, ṝ, e, ai, o,* and *au* are long.

When these vowel letters are joined with consonants, they form syllabic combinations called *guṇitāksharas*.

क् + अ = क (*k* + *a* = *ka*).

क् + आ = का (*k* + *ā* = *kā*).

One independent vowel or one such consonant–vowel combination is called an *akshara*, a syllabic unit. A bare consonant is not reckoned as an *akshara*. Thus अवाक् (*avāk*) contains two syllabic units, अ and वा.

1. All short vowels and syllables containing a short vowel are called *laghu*, or light. Their symbol is U, written above the syllable.

2. All long vowels and syllables containing a long vowel are called *guru*, or heavy; their symbol is a short horizontal stroke (—) above the syllable.

3. All syllables containing *anusvāra* or *visarga* are counted as heavy.

4. A syllable followed by a conjunct consonant or a consonant without its own vowel is counted as heavy, as in अच् (*ach*) and सत्य (*satya*). In these examples the अ and स are both heavy.

Just as a syllable bearing *anusvāra* or *visarga* is said to become long, the combination of a short vowel with *chandrabindu* is now treated as short.

That is: *chandrabindu* + short vowel = 1 *mātrā*.

The quantities in conjunct syllables are counted as follows:

क्ति = क् + त् + इ = 0 + 0 + 1 = 1.

क्ती = क् + त् + ई = 0 + 0 + 2 = 2.

क्ष = क् + ष = 0 + 1.

त्र = त् + र = 0 + 1.

ज्ञ = ज् + ञ = 0 + 1.

श्र = श् + र = 0 + 1.

स्र = स् + र = 0 + 1.

शृ = श् + ऋ = 0 + 1.

त्व = त् + व = 0 + 1.

त्त्व = त् + त् + व = 0 + 0 + 1.

Short vowel + ऽ (*bikari*) = 1 + 0.

The supplementary *bikari* sign should not be placed after an independent *a* or a long vowel: forms such as दिअऽ, आऽ, and ओऽ are faulty. The sign may, however, be placed after a consonant combined with the inherent *a*.

Short vowel + *chandrabindu* = 1 + 0.

Long vowel + *chandrabindu* = 2 + 0.

For example, हँसल (*hāsal*, "laughed") = 1 + 1 + 1.

साँस (*sās*, "breath") = 2 + 1.

Bikari and *chandrabindu* count as zero additional *mātrās*.

जा कऽ ("having gone") = 2 + 1.

क् = 0.

क = क् + अ = 0 + 1.

Because Maithili has developed a tendency to pronounce क as the bare consonant क्, the supplementary *bikari* sign became necessary. No such sign is needed for long vowels.

U denotes a short syllable.

I denotes a long syllable.

One long syllable (I) = two short units (U + U).

Syllabic Counting

Count a conjunct syllable as one; do not count the *halant*, *bikari*, or the vowel signs for *i*, *ā*, and the like separately. In syllabic metre only the number of syllabic units is counted. A consonant with *halant* does not count independently. A syllable bearing the signs for *e*, *u*, and other vowels counts as one, just as a conjunct syllable does. Every letter from *a* through *ha* counts as one. No syllable is assigned a double count. Keep the following three points in mind:

1. Consonant with *halant* = 0.

2. Conjunct syllable = 1.

3. Every syllable from *a* to *ha* = 1.

Consider the first example:

ई अरदराक मेघ नहि मानत रहत बरसि के ("These clouds of Ardra will not stop raining") = 1 + 5 + 2 + 2 + 3 + 3 + 1 = 17 syllabic units.

Now the second example:

पश्चात् (*pashchāt*) = 2 units.

Now the third example:

आब (*āb*, "now") = 2 units.

Now the fourth example:

स्क्रिप्ट (*script*) = 2 units.

The seven principal Vedic metres are Gāyatrī, Uṣṇih, Anuṣṭubh, Bṛhatī, Paṅkti, Triṣṭubh, and Jagatī. The others are their variants, including *atichhand* and *vichchhand*. A metre is identified by its syllabic units. If the prescribed number is incomplete, one or two syllables may be added in each *pāda*. The conjuncts containing *ya* and *va* may be separated by adding *i* and *u*, respectively, as follows:

Conjuncts involving *ya* and *va* may be separated by inserting *i* and *u*, respectively. For example:

वरेण्यम् (*vareṇyam*) → वरेणियम् (*vareṇiyam*).

स्वः (*svaḥ*) → सुवः (*suvaḥ*).

The requisite number of syllables may also be attained by separating *guṇa* and *vṛddhi* vowels.

ए = अ + इ (*e* = *a* + *i*).

ओ = अ + उ (*o* = *a* + *u*).

ऐ = अ/आ + ए (*ai* = *a*/*ā* + *e*).

औ = अ/आ + ओ (*au* = *a*/*ā* + *o*).

In simple syllabic metre the short–long distinction is disregarded. It may nevertheless be applied within syllabic metre, since later Vedic syllabic verse came to take that distinction into account. Consider the following example:

तकैत रहैत छी ऐ मेघ दिस — "I keep looking towards these clouds."

तकैत (*takait*): short + long + long; number of syllables = 3.

रहैत (*rahait*): short + long + short; number of syllables = 3.

छी (*chhī*): long; number of syllables = 1.

ऐ (*ai*): long; number of syllables = 1.

मेघ (*megh*): long + short; number of syllables = 2.

दिस (*dis*): short + short; number of syllables = 2.

In quantitative metre, the categories *dvikala*, *trikala*, *chatushkala*, *panchakala*, and *shatkala* can comprise anything from one syllable (a single long one) to six syllables (six short ones).

Dvikala contains two *mātrās*: either one long syllable or two short syllables.

Trikala contains three *mātrās*, in any of three sequences: short + long, long + short, or short + short + short.

Chatushkala totals four *mātrās*, *panchakala* five, and *shatkala* six.

Syllabic metre employs eight kinds of groups of three syllables each, which can be memorised by the formula यमाताराजसलगम् (*yamātārājasalagam*).

The number of feet, the positions of the caesurae (*yati*), the requirement of end-rhyme, and the arrangement of syllables can now be chosen on a syllabic or quantitative basis; this allows the poet to introduce variety.

In syllabic metre a group of three syllables is called a *gaṇa*. There are eight such groups:

Yagaṇa: U | |

Ragaṇa: | U |

Tagaṇa: | | U

Bhagaṇa: | U U

Jagaṇa: U | U

Sagaṇa: U U |

Magaṇa: | | |

Nagaṇa: U U U

Besides these eight, there are two more single-unit *gaṇas*, *ga* and *la*.

Ga-gaṇa: a single long syllable, |.

La-gaṇa: a single short syllable, U.

One mnemonic formula for remembering all eight *gaṇas* is:

यमाताराजभानसलगम् (*yamātārājabhānasalagam*).

Let us now divide this formula:

यमाता (*yamātā*): U । । = *yagaṇa.*

मातारा (*mātārā*): । । । = *magaṇa.*

ताराज (*tārāja*): । । U = *tagaṇa.*

राजभा (*rājabhā*): । U । = *ragaṇa.*

जभान (*jabhāna*): U । U = *jagaṇa.*

भानस (*bhānasa*): । U U = *bhagaṇa.*

नसल (*nasala*): U U U = *nagaṇa.*

सलगम् (*salagam*): U U । = *sagaṇa.*

13. The Critical Theory of Maithili Prose and Poetry

Abstract

When the printing press first appeared, it was characterised as belonging to the bourgeois class. The novel, too, emerged with the arrival of printing and was accordingly regarded as bourgeois literature; gradually, however, that assumption disappeared. Literature on the Internet will certainly remain a complement to printed literature. Those who do not wish to read on a computer screen will print the text and read it. Pothi.com and other websites and publishers also offer print-on-demand services. For Maithili, the regularity of publication made possible by the Internet, the removal of distribution difficulties, negligible cost, and the overcoming of geographical distance have proved a blessing.

Keywords: prose · poetry · literary criticism · critical theory · Maithili

A Critical Theory for Maithili

The Future of Maithili on the Internet

When the printing press first appeared, it was characterised as belonging to the bourgeois class. The novel, too, arrived with printing and was therefore considered bourgeois literature, but that view gradually disappeared. Literature on the Internet will certainly remain a complement to printed literature. Those who do not read on a computer screen will print the material and read it. Pothi.com and other websites and publishers are also providing print-on-demand facilities.

For Maithili, the regularity of publication through the Internet, the removal of distribution problems, publication at no cost, and the abolition of geographical distance have proved a blessing.

The Internet transmits information instantly, but the possibilities of misuse are greater than those of use, particularly the practice of changing names, posting comments through different Internet service providers, and engaging in blackmail. There are ways of exposing such practices, but they too result in a waste of energy.

Introduction to the Participants

Fiction: Members of the educated middle class who have studied Maithili as a language or mother tongue from the ninth standard through undergraduate and postgraduate education retain an affection for it. The arrival of Maithili on the Internet has also reawakened affection for the mother tongue. Maithili books, including textbooks published by government institutions, have not been readily obtainable. The Internet has intervened in this difficulty, though only to a limited extent. As a consequence of these conditions, an inferiority complex has entered the

minds of Maithili writers—a superiority complex, too, is a form of inferiority complex—and literature has begun to be erected on factional support. Literary discussion based on controversies, charges, and countercharges has begun. Husbands and wives, people of the same district or locality, and fathers and sons have started constructing an atmosphere in favour of their own sides. In other words, stories and poems are being written for prizes through blackmailing and black-marketing. Yet even literature that has won the Booker Prize or the Nobel Prize in Literature does not necessarily remain timeless: people remember many works, but many others are forgotten, and readers arrive at their own evaluations. In Maithili, however, generations pass without an adequate readership, while husbands and wives, fathers and sons, people from the same districts and localities, and, now, factions formed by fiction writers and poets judge literature on the basis of such blackmailing. Because the Internet's intervention has remained limited, good literature, creative literature, and literature beneficial to society have neither come adequately into view nor been sufficiently created. Whom will you encourage: the poets and fiction writers who keep themselves in the news by generating controversies and practising blackmail, or the humanist poets and fiction writers who live amid dust and hardship? Only when you make that choice will you be able to breathe life into a Maithili literature that has come to appear futile.

Poetry: People read little poetry. Efforts are being made to disseminate a language such as Sanskrit; simple Sanskrit is used in conversational workshops. Works of fiction and novels are translated from modern languages into Sanskrit, but poetry remains outside this process. The reason is that hardly anyone reads poetry, and translating poetry into a language that needs instructional camps for its survival is considered an unproductive expenditure of energy. The position of Maithili has become somewhat similar: if its villages were to disappear today, the number of people speaking the language would become very small. People would speak Maithili only at seminars and gatherings. The need for workshops on Maithili pronunciation is already being felt. Under these circumstances, what is the need or justification for writing poetry in Maithili? When a poet stresses that poems are written for want of time, the situation appears still more alarming. Events in the neighbourhood, personal ambitions, accusations, and travel accounts have thus become the subject matter of Maithili poetry. But why not use prose for such things? Stories are adapted into drama for the theatre; for what purpose, then, is prose turned into poetry? The readers of these poems, written under the pressure of insufficient time, are critics engaged in factional manoeuvring and the self-proclaimed great poets who transform prose into verse and, through their own prefaces, supply favourable reviews of their own poems. Who will understand the worth of poetic creation? Personal, worldly experience that

fails to penetrate deeply cannot become great poetry, even when it rhymes. Otherworldly reflection, however abstract, cannot move us if it remains unconnected with worldly life, however much free verse, factional support, or ideological backing it possesses. Human beings need food, clothing, and shelter, and only thereafter otherworldly reflection. The Buddha asks whether everyone participating in these festivities knows that death is inevitable; if they do, how can they continue celebrating? In the same way, when modern Maithili poets see the linguistic, cultural, and economic foundations of their lives disappearing from under their feet, yet close their eyes and refuse to acknowledge the truth, the ideologies of national and international events which they wish to thrust into their poems lose their force. Their writing intended as a favour to the indigenous Dalit community, and their desire to bestow benefits upon it, lack sharpness. Yet when Rajdev Mandal writes poetry—

> ...
> Drop by drop, the blood falls,
> and the earth is bathed in it.
> A bird asks itself
> this one question:
> Will our kind survive
> this dark and heavy night that approaches ...?

—we are shaken. What is the 'kind' of the poet's poetic being, and what is the kind to which the bird belongs? What need has this poem of factional manoeuvring or a self-absorbed preface? What faction or ideological support does this sensibility require? Poetry, then, needs excellence. It needs a linguistic and cultural foundation. It does not need merely imported subject matter brought in as an act of condescension; nor does it need imported sensibility that makes only a superficial, patronising attempt to recover a vanishing language, culture, and economic foundation. Good poetry can be written on any subject. It can address the Buddha's concern for humanity's future and lend support to unsettled minds; otherwise people will continue attending the sermons of fraudulent holy men. It can address the linguistic, cultural, and economic foundations of society; otherwise camps will have to be organised to teach Maithili itself. The communicability of imagery is essential as well. Otherwise an atmosphere will have to be prepared for a poet in advance, a stage arranged for his poetry, and training camps held to explain his vocabulary and ideology—and poets have indeed been doing precisely these things. The gentle rises and falls of Mithila's language, the manifold capacities of its proletarian classes, and also the rigidity of local ways of life and culture, politics, daily routines, social conventions, economic conditions, morality, religion, and philosophy should enter its literature. Without them literature will become one-sided, lose its balance, and end up fit only to be framed and hung upon a wall. Writing poetry is a literary

compulsion. The day it becomes necessary to organise camps to teach the people of Mithila their own Maithili language, the existence of poetry itself may be called into question. Poets must remain alert so that day never comes.

Essential Elements of Maithili Criticism

We must consider the essential elements involved in the criticism of Maithili stories and poems.

Identify new problems that have emerged in a changed environment.

Identify attempts to connect personal experience with public life.

Determine whether a work has structural coherence; identify literature used for blackmail through the tendency to insert controversial material and forcibly plant ideological symbols within a work.

Writers who employ literature as blackmail may use stories and poems for personal self-praise and attacks on others. An evaluation based on facts, however, will expose this tendency.

How can literature afflicted with an inferiority complex promote the public good?

Trace one-sided representation against the background of changing social, economic, political, and religious relationships.

The instability in a writer's personal life, whether in commitment to an ideology or to caste and religion, reveals itself in literature. Such writing, even after repeated revision and expansion, cannot escape its original defect. Casteism and communalism reappear. These tendencies must be identified.

Distinguish gossip from criticism. Its chief characteristics are as follows:

"Someone once asked him—I hear he wanted to do this ..." and similar remarks. Then there are assertions that neither readers nor critics can understand the writer's work, although some supposed essential truth about him is known to the speaker. This writer is someone's son, so he writes well—or badly. He holds a particular post, therefore his writing is good—or bad. He has money and owns a hotel, so he cannot be a writer; the other distributes leaflets and is a journalist, so he is a great writer. He comes from Saharsa or Supaul, so he writes well—or badly; the other is from the Sot region of Darbhanga, or is a Brahmin or a Kayastha, so his writing must be good—or bad.

The one-line verdict: "I oppose this work," or "I support it." "He is a good person to me, so he writes well." "He belongs to my caste, or will benefit

me in the future, so his writing is marvellous." "If I praise him, he will praise me." All these tendencies must be identified.

Identify prejudice or hatred directed towards someone in the course of evaluation, and the practice of delivering a verdict before understanding the whole matter.

In Maithili literature, where the number of readers is virtually zero, one writer reviews another, leaving ample scope for personal ego and blackmail. Attend a few literary gatherings of poets and fiction writers: the announcer's introductions and the applause will reveal the prejudices of both the announcer and the writers. Gaurinath writes that, even in Hindi, collections are presented under labels such as "Premchand, Mohan Rakesh and the writer from Uttarakhand", as though that Uttarakhand writer stood in the same category as Premchand and Mohan Rakesh. In Maithili, too, we hear "Kulanand Mishra, Harekrishna Jha, and this writer"; "Yatri, Rajkamal, and that one"; or "Rajkamal, Lalit, and this one", as though these alone were the poets and fiction writers who mattered. The biased double standards involved in these assertions are readily apparent. Read widely—Maithili literature on both sides of the India–Nepal border. During that reading, identify the works and writers you consider good, and those supposedly established authors or works you consider poor. Identify the inconsistencies as well, without fear. Courage is essential to end the dominance of blackmailers and of writers who form factions around stories and poems. In the absence of readers, they have propped up Maithili literature through group patronage and created an artificial literary atmosphere.

12. Freedom and reservation: Both are subjects of noisy polemic. The exploiting classes argue that independence was superficial, voting is fraudulent, and reservation rests on discrimination. Yet independence produced the vote, and every five years elections give rise to numerous new configurations of social change that benefit exploited groups. Granting the same rights to people occupying unequal social positions cannot, by itself, produce equality. The exploiting classes will then say that hierarchies are also emerging within reserved categories. But those are not hierarchies established on the basis of caste, and they are less severe than those of earlier times. Why should the Shudra sage Kavasha Ailusha, seer of Vedic hymns, or the woman Apala, likewise a seer of Vedic hymns, have remained on the margins? Older social arrangements imposed rankings within castes; the genealogical *panji* system ranked Karna Kayasthas and Maithil Brahmins internally; wealth and influence shaped further hierarchies, assigning people higher or lower positions. Contemporary arrangements still preserve, as signs of absurdity, practices based on support for child marriage, opposition to widow remarriage, and genealogical

registers. Society becomes self-centred and abandons its language and culture because its affection for them has, since childhood, been little more than symbolic. Education remains unequal even now, but the difference from the earlier situation is as great as that between earth and sky. A person can study, enter the highest levels of society, and require neither a genealogy register nor any other support. Such a person may rise from a village panchayat to membership of Parliament. One may undertake contracting work or operate buses and tempos. If someone now says, "I could not study, and so I could not become a district collector," others respond, "Then how did so-and-so's son manage to become one?"

13. Patronising representation: Identify the feeling of superiority— itself a form of inferiority complex—in poems or stories written about the oppressed by their oppressors, either as an act of benevolence towards them or under the pressure of guilt.

14. Identify mediocrity: Catchphrases and the latest breaking news are presented in the name of modernity. Such writing offers no thinking capable of overturning the axioms of an age, and therefore criticism of international events—Bush and Saddam, for instance—lacks force. Whether such writers support or oppose a temple or mosque, Nandigram or Lalgarh, their work remains equally blunt. Their views on humanism, secularism, the Left and the Right, after drinking themselves into a stupor, sound half-asleep. They insert the vocabulary of the times and declare a poem or story finished. How can criticism of America have bite, or support for the Left carry conviction, when the writer's livelihood depends upon help from the Right? The absence of struggle diminishes creativity over time instead of increasing it. Everyone moves with the age; to move against its current requires the strength of creativity. Identify these convenience-seeking figures who call others escapists but cannot themselves penetrate beneath the surface. Contact with history may link a writer to a historical consciousness. An author burdened by inferiority and guilt cannot write with the force required to challenge prevailing social arrangements. The realism of Nyaya-Vaisheshika and Samkhya-Yoga, the reality of the external world and resistance to illusion, household life, and the public good must be considered. Works of art and literature rest on the indivisible knowledge and wisdom within the self: movement, freedom, and creative transformation. We cannot alter history or literary history, and yet the golden age of Mithila is reconstructed out of upper- and middle-class memories. Such memories may possess relevance only for television and cinema. Liberalism: the success and failure of industrialisation and its economic development. Freedom and reservation gave wider expression to the protest of socially disadvantaged groups, while also diminishing its intensity, whether in Naxalism, Maoism, or Marxism–Leninism. That benefited the bourgeoisie. Bourgeois political

and cultural organisations expanded, attempting to reach the proletariat and include women. Money and convenience broke down traditional morality. The company established an independent identity, and families and individuals began running such enterprises through salaried employees. Control over nature and observation of human behaviour; food for work and money in exchange for work; employment-guarantee programmes and public-distribution shops. Travel within and beyond national borders for work made distances smaller and struck at the foundations of family life. Within the capitalist world economy, change does not come of its own accord but through struggle and effort. Independent human sensibility guarantees neither a good future nor a bad one. We have choices, and the signs now appearing of a revival of Maithili literature are not insignificant. We must decide which alternative to pursue: creating sensations or doing the work.

15. In India, following the political revolution, the aim was to bring about industrial and social revolutions; in developed countries, social revolutions had taken place before industrial revolutions. That is why we had to face difficult circumstances. Alongside social customs, modes of thinking, perspectives, and their development, there are questions of nutrition, health, sanitation, medicine, education, rising life expectancy, and declining mortality. Modernisation, democratisation, the implementation of the nation-state concept, administrative and legal development, increasing public participation, stability and the capacity for orderly change, the dynamics of power, and industrialisation all belong to this inquiry.

16. The division of society into rich and poor: the size and standing of the two classes, and the distance separating them.

17. Following independence, the new state faced political, social, economic, and cultural problems; the processes of change and integration were sometimes mutually contradictory. Anthropological, ethnic, religious, and linguistic loyalties; primary and smaller affiliations; local, caste-based, religious, and linguistic commitments: these must be considered, as must the development of community life and psychological and educational processes.

18. Indigenous communities: Groups such as the Satar and Gidarmara reflect diversity and differing levels of development. Closeness to nature, nature worship, simplicity, innocence, and gratitude; the sun, social and religious festivals, worship of the sun, moon, trees, and mountains, praise of the earth, and belief in bodies of water and the constellations are all part of their world. *Janaka*, the author suggests, derives from *jana* (*vish*, the people); such beliefs also exist among the inhabitants of Mithila.

19. A person's social standing is determined by location and caste. Certain castes enjoy prestige and privilege; others face contempt and difficult lives. Scheduled Castes: 1,100 in the first governmental list; Backward Castes: 3,743 according to the Mandal Commission; total: 4,843. The *varna* system is not a religious requirement but a social custom that has no present use. It may be exploited as a divisive force by a foreign mentality or a rigidly entrenched one.

20. Women and child development: Women's rights require an active educational system, the inclusion of women's studies in curricula, and an increase in women's participation in vocational and technical education. Women must have a place in dynamic management and development processes. Their participation in the independence movement, environmental and anti-dowry movements, and the struggle for economic equality must be recognised. Nurseries, childcare homes, *balwadis*, and *anganwadis* are needed for the children of working women. Competition brings low wages, adverse working conditions, and a socially and culturally undervalued position.

21. Women's emancipation and the women's movement.

22. Secularism: Political institutions should rest on the economic and social interests of the entire community, without distinctions of religion, race, or sect. Divisions between individuals or groups on grounds of religious belief or social origin must be rejected. Every community should exercise power in a spirit of responsibility and duty—that is, distributive justice. There should be no discrimination on religious grounds, and the state must not be controlled by religion.

23. Tagore's aestheticism; Gandhi's moralism; Aurobindo Ghose's mystical spiritual philosophy; and Vivekananda's practical Vedanta.

24. If development is educational before it is economic, ordinary people can participate in it. This enhances creative capacity and develops a sense of responsibility within community and national life.

25. Science and technology, and the differences between developed and underdeveloped nations: the aspiration to solve human problems, disease, ignorance, and insecurity, and the hope and foundation for the limitless expansion of facilities. In this way individual and national capacities increase.

26. The legal system should be used to deliver justice to the poor and disadvantaged. Village justice councils, or *nyaya panchayats*, should be revived.

27. Civil liberties: Human democratic rights, freedom of thought, and the creation of a capable society free from restrictions and pressure, together with protection against the suppression of rights.

28. The press: It connects rulers and the ruled and plays a role in social, economic, and political life. Powerful advertising agencies, however, now shape public opinion. The press should safeguard stability and act as a sentinel and protector of democracy. Industrialists own newspapers and governments direct administration, placing press freedom at risk. The danger is especially acute for countries such as Nepal and India.

29. The creation of new institutions or the reform of existing ones, in opposition to feudal, tribal, caste-based, and sectarian loyalties: democracy, liberalism, republicanism, constitutionalism, socialism, egalitarianism, constitutional rights, regular popular elections, popular sovereignty, federal division of powers, the importance of public opinion, public-administration processes and initiatives, the consolidation of party interests, a supreme legislature, an accountable executive, and an independent judiciary.

30. Water, land, air, and the sky: pollution and ecological imbalance caused by harmful changes in their physical, chemical, and biological properties.

31. Art: Must it possess a theoretical purpose? Art is a form of social sensibility and human activity; it is an aesthetic presentation of the world. The art of beauty is related to utility, and the philosophy of artistic perfection to schools of thought.

32. Emotional atmosphere: An aesthetic contemplation of truth and of artistic activity, of the beautiful, the concrete, and the abstract. Nature and distinctively artistic states may be powerful, sorrowful, or comic; the human experience of beauty cannot exist without experience itself. Here emerges a way of looking at the aesthetic transformation of society.

33. Mental activity: The human being is a thinking creature, experiencing both mental and physical reality: body and brain, the day's work and the night's dreams.

34. Contradiction or deceptive appearance; ambiguity; theoretical advantage.

35. Kant's philosophy: Throw a fishing net with openings two inches wide into a pond and you will catch no fish smaller than two inches. Would you then conclude that there are no smaller fish in the pond? The finer the critic's net, the better.

36. Literature for children and adolescents: Children and young readers who encounter Maithili literature will return to the language later, once their studies and employment are settled. Why should those who did not study Maithili at school or college, and never read Maithili children's literature, develop an affection for it? If you do not seek them out, they will not seek the language out either.

37. Sagar Rati Deep Jaray *and Maithili criticism: Wars have social, economic, political, and immediate causes. Memorise only the immediate ones, and pronounce everything else wholly bad—the economic situation was bad, the social situation was bad, and so on. But apply that explanation to the French Revolution and it fails: at that time French peasants were economically better off than their English counterparts, which helped make revolution and resistance possible in France. Criticism of* Sagar Rati Deep Jaray* is conducted in much the same manner: "The craftsmanship is good, the subject matter is good …"

38. Dalit literature: Apart from Mahendra Narayan Ram, Bilat Paswan Vihangam, and a few others, Dalit writers and Dalit literature in Maithili are virtually absent.

39. Khesari (grass pea), Magh, mangoes and the autumn season, the comet, *Mor Par*; the dates of Ashadh and other months only two pages apart in a novel by Yatri; Mohan Bharadwaj; Kumar Pawan.

On page 1 of *Mor Par*, the heads of rice stand erect in one line and elsewhere droop under their weight, while a dense, richly green carpet of grass pea stretches for miles—an image of the latter's final stage. But grass pea appears only after Aghan, after the paddy harvest; its earlier sprouting would precede that final stage by still more time.

Yatri Samagra, page 220: the aunt's death anniversary fell on Jeth Shukla Chaturdashi. The earlier anniversary … Page 222: "How could I go even for a single day to act as the ritual performer, on Ashadh Krishna Tritiya—the first …"

In his review of *Balchanma*, Mohan Bharadwaj writes that someone asked Yatri Ji about writing a second part of *Balchanma*, and Yatri supposedly replied that by now Balchanma must have become a *dhodhi*. Who was this person who questioned Yatri—a fictitious question-and-answer exchange? Anyone who has read *Balchanma* knows that Balchanma was beaten and killed. Why would Yatri tell an imaginary questioner that the dead Balchanma would have become a *dhodhi*?

Kumar Pawan's *Paith* is among the finest Maithili stories; nevertheless its ending, with a quarrel between two brothers and so forth, could have been directed towards a different objective—for example, exploitation.

Art: Must It Have a Theoretical Purpose?

The various literary forms—poetry, treatises, essays, criticism, short fiction, novels, epistolary literature, travel memoirs, reportage, drama, and one-act plays—are heard, recited, read, or performed for entertainment. They may have a purpose, or they may embrace purposelessness and absurdity: amid life's upheavals, literature without a declared purpose can also entertain.

In ancient times, art, literature, and music were transmitted from one generation to the next. *Padapāṭha*, *kramapāṭha*, *jaṭāpāṭha*, *śikhāpāṭha*, and *ghanapāṭha* were systematic methods of memorisation. The *Yajurveda* described ways of constructing houses, sacrificial altars, and other works of art; the commentaries developed these descriptions further, providing a very early foundation for archaeology. Its method of music gave the *Sāmaveda* its distinctive character. There were thus efforts to establish systems for literature, art, and music, so that other people could reproduce them in the same manner. In this process, criticism of art, literature, and music—or the analysis of their qualities—began. Eastern and Western thinkers also offered views on the social purposes of art, literature, and music and the ethical standards they ought to follow. Plato holds that no art can be good because all art is false and unreal.

Yet art, music, and literature may also be created for one's own delight. Reading, hearing, seeing, or experiencing them may give pleasure and mental peace, while at other moments they may provoke agitation. Aristotle, however, argues that artists possess knowledge and help us to understand the world.

In *Rigveda* 1.115.2, the image of the rising sun at dawn is that of a young man following a beautiful woman. In *Rigveda* 1.124.11, the reddish glow of sunrise, the retreating darkness, and the fire in the hearth are described through the image of a village maiden releasing a red cow to graze. *Atharvaveda* 4.15.6 describes a collective cry or slogan. *Yajurveda* 40.16 describes the solar disc as a golden vessel covering the sun. *Yajurveda* 17.38–41 depicts a divine army going into battle accompanied by instruments, while 17.49 describes the rustling sound of armour. *Rigveda* 1.164.2 and Yāska 4.27 describe the year and the wheel. *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* 2.2.3 describes the source of *soma* juice, while 2.2.4 refers to the seven sages at its banks as the eyes, ears, and so forth. In *Atharvaveda* 10.2.31 the body is called Ayodhya; in the *Bhagavad Gītā* 5.13 it is called a city.

Through the utterance of words and the creation of art, the object to be apprehended comes into being. Its justification is established through words and sounds, form, *rasa*, *rāga*, metre, and figures of speech.

Art is the aesthetic presentation of the world. The art of beauty exists in relation to utility; the philosophy of artistic perfection stands in relation

to schools of thought. Emotional atmosphere involves an aesthetic contemplation of truth and artistic action, the beautiful in both concrete and abstract form.

Mental activity: a human being thinks and experiences both mental and physical reality. Contradiction or deceptive appearance entails ambiguity. Marxism champions the social realism of the novel.

Freud regards every human being as mysterious. He selects literary works for the analysis of their authors, whereas neo-Freudian thought places greater emphasis on cultural than on biological elements.

New Criticism is based on a detailed examination of the work.

Postmodernism, existentialism, and humanism are philosophical currents. Earlier, philosophy included science, history, society and politics, economics, art, scientific inquiry, and language. Yet as the branches of science and art became increasingly specialised—science in particular—philosophy came to be confined, in relation to mathematics and science, to mathematical logic. Philosophers turned towards inductive and deductive methods of inquiry and analytical methods.

Marx, who was almost a form of divine intervention for the poor throughout the world, made the dialectical method the foundation of his explanation. Today's "discussion", or debate, which contains both a proposition and its opposition, already existed in philosophy—in particular in the six philosophical systems—as the method of refutation and defence. See Mādhavācārya's *Sarvadarśanasaṃgraha*.

Francis Fukuyama, who proclaimed the end of history after the fall of communist rule, later withdrew from that position. Postmodernism, too, has faltered after its initial enthusiasm.

Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, Romanticism, and sociological analysis have survived by becoming part of synthetic approaches to criticism.

Because psychoanalysis is grounded in scientific inquiry, it will survive, like the dialectical method.

Psychology may also provide the foundation of a story. The purposes of a story should accord with the needs of society, and the changes in its narrative journey should respond to changes that have occurred or are occurring in that society. At the same time, the story is itself governed by the society's culture, and its historical existence comes into view through it. Vedic narratives, for example, bring forth love for the nation and teach people to live together in society. The *Jātaka* tales, while disseminating the people's languages, also seek to spread Buddhism. In the Muslim world, Rumi's *Masnavi*, a distinctive work of Persian literature, teaches the importance of knowledge and the advancement of the state.

Contemporary fiction brings these elements together and moves towards the creation of an enlightened and humane society.

After the collapse of communism, it appeared that history—understood as the struggle between two ideologies—had come to an end because one of those ideologies had disappeared. Francis Fukuyama declared that this marked the end of history produced by ideological conflicts and that only an ideology concerned with human welfare would now move forward. But later he acknowledged that many competing ideologies continued to exist within societies and among nationalities.

The postmodern outlook questions the completeness of scientific knowledge. Truth and falsehood are described from differing perspectives; its humour can be self-centred; distinctions between good and bad repeatedly dissolve, and there is no certainty about when truth might become falsehood. Thinking may be superficial. There is neither optimism nor pessimism, only a kind of absurdity: a thing can be considered in many different ways, not just one. It puts less faith in outcomes derived from causes, control, and plans, and more faith in chance. Democratic and feminist viewpoints, red flags, and other ideological emblems may become objects of playful irony. Postmodernism brought forward the questions facing women and many communities marginalised from the mainstream by globalisation. It opposed ideology and universal goals, yet could offer no answer.

Similarly, the postmodern thinker Jacques Derrida deconstructed language and argued that its separated elements depend on numerous different foundations; without understanding those dependencies, we cannot establish its meaning.

To restore dialogue, the fiction writer must also possess faith—a faith founded both on reasoning and on experience.

The analytical philosophy of positivism examines linguistic statements and concepts rather than objects themselves.

Analytical, or logical, positivism and existentialism arose as reactions to science. In this way, the ambiguities of scientific thought were clarified.

Phenomenology studies what is given to consciousness precisely as it is given. Experience is the observation of the facts of a particular mental act. It offers a way of seeing an object without prejudice and in its pure form.

In existentialism, the human being is nothing other than the human being himself. Apart from what he creates, he is nothing; he is condemned to be free, as Sartre says.

Hegel's dialectic stresses judgements of quality and existence through the endless interrelationship of analysis and synthesis. The deeper an essential

principle lies, the further it is from outward form and the closer it comes to reality.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also influenced modern thinking. Beneath visible reality, internal and external processes operate through exchanges among minute units of force and energy. Under the uncertainty principle, position and form must be determined through approximation.

The conception of a universe of more than three dimensions, and Stephen Hawking's *A Brief History of Time*, directly challenge the existence of God, for they also bring forward the idea of God's death. Whatever begins must end, however long its life may be.

Just as virtual reality artificially presents reality and merges consciousness with it, so, without imagining more than three dimensions, even if we had travelled at the speed of light from the time of the Indus Valley civilisation, we would still not have reached the far side of the universe today.

All these scientific and philosophical propositions have emerged as challenges before literature. A holistic, or comprehensive, synthesis is needed. Only then will this philosophy become real rather than merely philosophical.

Poststructuralist methodology locates the meaning of language not in words, their lexical meanings, or grammatical rules, but in the process through which meaning is produced. Language acquires different meanings for different people and groups. There is no final relationship between language and the world. Neither a word nor its text possesses a final or uniquely fixed meaning. Modernity emerged through the exchanges of modern and postmodern reasoning, reality, dialogue, and ideas.

Then the New Left movement arose in France, alongside such currents as catastrophism and anarchism. These were founded on distrust of the beliefs and assumptions of modern intellectual systems. Hidden meanings in texts began to be interpreted in relation to time and place, while language was turned into a medium of play—a "language game". Postmodernism emerged as a critique of power, legitimacy, and their stratification.

In the computer and information revolution, a programmer creates software and places it on the worldwide Internet, where the software continues to work independently of its maker. Sometimes it even performs tasks for which its maker never designed it. Other programs, such as viruses, interfere with its course and turn it destructive; antivirus programs are software that repair the damage. When even these do not work, a backup is taken and the computer formatted: a clean slate!

Capitalism was born of the Industrial Revolution, but in post-industrial society information and communication have become more important than production, and the computer has assumed a larger role in society. Mobile phones, credit cards, and similar objects are based on chips. The ideas of deconstruction and reconstruction reveal a restructuring of the creative process through which consciousness takes new forms in the post-industrial age. History has not ended, but traditional history has. The state, class, nation, political party, society, family, morality, and marriage are all being redefined. Under the impact of so many changes, numerous institutions have become fragmented and lost their context.

An information society, or information-based society, is one in which the creation, distribution, dissemination, use, integration, and modification of information constitute major economic, political, and cultural activities. People capable of participating in such a society are called digital citizens. In this post-industrial society, information technology determines production, the economy, and society. The idea is closely related to such concepts as postmodern society and post-industrial society. The economist Fritz Machlup proposed the concept. His account of the knowledge industry had five components: education, research and development, the media, information technology, and information services. It thus demonstrates the effects of technology and information upon society. The digital divide is also a divide in knowledge, a social division, and an economic division. It indicates the necessity of constructing a non-discriminatory information society in which developing countries enjoy sovereign rights over information technology.

The right to privacy is also involved in the relationship between human rights and information technology. Scholars, human-rights activists, and others have begun debating whether an information society based on information and communication technologies will strengthen or damage human rights, with particular reference to freedom of expression, the right to information, privacy, discrimination, equality for women, intellectual property, political participation, and freedom of association. The confidentiality of online correspondence, the cultural and linguistic diversity of Internet content, and media education are among the matters at stake. The technical instruments of the information society participate in its rights and freedoms, and contribute to society's overall development, to the universality of rights and liberties, and to the negotiation of conflicting rights, freedoms, and values. They create easier access to information, knowledge, and culture, and transform the user into an actor in the global information society. They provide greater freedom of expression than before, as well as the capacity to create new content and new social networks. This also creates a need for new legal, economic, and

social models founded upon shared responsibility, knowledge, and understanding. The welfare of children is another concern; it must always take precedence over the interests of adults.

The accumulation of economic, social, and cultural wealth has intensified in the information society, while technology has produced a structural form of unemployment. Poverty, workers' rights, and the idea of the welfare state are being pushed aside before calculations of profit and loss. Only a few participants now seem to be needed. Publishers, too, promote only the authors of a few best-selling books. The same tendency is visible in theatre, painting, cinema, and other fields. Information, however, is not invariably beneficial. Its domain is not confined to art and books: it also includes the speculative market and sponsored survey reports. It reduces the distance between time and place and establishes a balance between them. The concept of human dignity shifts attention away from a social position determined by birth towards a universal right to dignity. Liberation movements, including movements for women's liberation, have worked in this direction. After the two World Wars and the challenge of fascism, the United Nations General Assembly proclaimed and adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights on 10 December 1948. The declaration established common standards for all peoples and nations without political, economic, cultural, or religious discrimination.

Yet the free use of information is limited, and privacy is disappearing. When Bill Gates, during a visit to India, was asked whether Microsoft's Xbox had been launched late in India for fear of piracy, he reportedly answered that Microsoft had never delayed a product because of such fear. The fear of spam and piracy must be overcome. The information society is the society in which we are now living. Democracy and human rights must continue to be respected in both the information society and the society that follows it. Freedom of expression, the right to privacy, the right to share information, and the right to access information—all associated with the communication of information—are threatened both by the state and by the market-oriented tendencies of the information society.

The Internet is a people's medium, a system that establishes communication among people. It breaks down the strongholds of those who monopolise the means of communication. Ordinarily, the Internet has no editor: people create subjects and content and communicate them themselves. This initiates numerous forms of social dialogue, but a great deal of antisocial material also appears. Should it be prohibited? If we give machines, through software, the power to prohibit content, this will be a serious blow to freedom of expression. Intellectual-property rights give rights of publication and distribution even sixty years after an author's

death. Piracy must also be prohibited on the Internet, and arrangements should be made so that an author's rights in the material continue for at least twenty years after death. Excessive resort to patents, however, will obstruct developing countries' access to information and hinder technological progress. Copyright can nevertheless foster cultural development, including the development of music, film, comics, and illustrated narratives. In a digital environment, material cannot even be viewed on the Internet without making a copy; thus online and offline copyright differ to some extent. Online copyright restricts reproduction as well, although reproducing material, incorporating it into something else, or altering it is very easy. Names and images should therefore not be used without their creators' permission; other people's private conversations and chats should not be invaded; and statements that create false impressions of others should not be circulated. Likewise, an employer's electronic surveillance of employees must conform to International Labour Organization guidelines. Unsolicited emails and the unauthorised collection or use of medical reports also violate human rights.

Internet use remains restricted because much content and software are expensive rather than freely available; the digital divide makes educational disparities more visible. Since information technology relies more on intellectual than on physical labour, one might expect women's inequality to decline in an information society, but surveys show that women have comparatively little access to information technology. Electronic libraries and Braille-enabled or audio-enabled computer screens could help disabled and blind people conduct e-commerce from home. Yet the high cost of research and its results in this field has prevented the expected benefits from being realised. Children, older people, disabled people, women, workers, migrant workers, and other socially disadvantaged groups experience disadvantage even within the information society.

Good literature or art is not created merely through the immediate presentation of an idea. Its foundation must be the sharply articulated human values, social harmony, and social principles grounded in equality and justice that it embodies. We must ask whether it clearly conveys how society can advance on that basis. Does it free the reader's mind from bondage? Does it foster the strength and confidence needed to lead others? Does it dispel doubts about character formation and respect for labour? All these become standards for judging short-short fiction. People living on society's margins can accomplish things beyond the capacity of those who enjoy every advantage; that is possible only when their self-confidence is strengthened.

How can literature burdened by an inferiority complex serve the public good? In changing social, economic, political, and religious circumstances,

one-sided depictions reveal the instability of a fiction writer's or poet's personal commitments, whether ideological or based on caste and religion. The sense of superiority that appears in stories written by an exploiter about the exploited, either as an act of benevolence or out of guilt, must be identified. That superiority itself is a form of inferiority complex.

Identify mediocrity: catchphrases and the latest breaking news masquerading as modernity. Such writing contains no thought capable of overturning the assumptions of an age. Modernisation, democratisation, the implementation of the nation-state concept, administrative and legal development, increased public participation, stability and the capacity for orderly change, the dynamics of power, industrialisation, and the post-independence processes of political, social, economic, and cultural change and integration within a new state may at times contradict one another. Community development and psychological and educational processes must also be considered.

Indigenous communities, such as the Satar and Gidarmara, reflect diversity and differing levels of development: closeness to nature, nature worship, simplicity, guilelessness, and gratitude. Individual standing is tied to place and caste. Some castes enjoy status and privilege; others face contempt and difficult lives.

Women and child development: women's rights, the activation of the education system, the inclusion of women's studies in curricula, and a greater proportion of women in vocational and technical education. Women's liberation and the women's movement. Secular political institutions founded on the economic and social interests of the entire community, without religious, racial, or sectarian distinctions. If development is educational before it is economic, ordinary people can participate in it. Their creativity grows and they acquire a sense of responsibility.

Science and technology, and the divide between developed and underdeveloped nations: human problems, illness, ignorance, insecurity, and the aspiration for solutions, hope, and an unlimited extension of facilities and their foundations. The legal order must be used to secure justice for the poor and disadvantaged. Civil liberties, democratic human rights, independent thought, the creation of a capable society, and freedom from restrictions and coercion. The press is a link between ruler and ruled, with a role in social, economic, and political life; influential advertising agencies, however, now also shape public opinion. The creation of new institutions or reform of existing ones, against feudal, tribal, caste-based, and sectarian loyalties; democracy, liberalism, republicanism, constitutionalism, socialism, egalitarianism, constitutional rights,

elections at regular intervals, popular sovereignty, the federal division of powers, the importance of public opinion, public-administrative processes and initiatives, the aggregation of party interests, a supreme legislature, an accountable executive, and an independent judiciary. Pollution and ecological imbalance arise from harmful changes in the physical, chemical, and biological characteristics of water, land, air, and the atmosphere. Must art, then, have a theoretical purpose?

Michel Foucault: knowledge and truth are produced.

Deleuze and Guattari say that we desire because we are desiring-machines.

Mikhail Bakhtin regards language as a social activity, and his work concerns the novel.

The Russian Formalists regard literature as a distinctive use of language.

Jean-François Lyotard: truth and the truthfulness of history are only apparent. Baudrillard: advertising and television have erased the distinction between the real and the simulated. Both are major thinkers of postmodernism.

Lacan's distinctive contribution is the linguistic application of Freud's method. He argues that the unconscious is structured like a language. When a child learns language, a word is taught for a sign. Lacan clearly presents three elements: desire, lack, and the Other. Desire involves both need and demand, but cannot be broken down into those two forms alone. Lack and an absence appear in the description of the Other. The subject is a momentary effect of meaning and becomes like the Other when it is imaginary and produces a lack from which desire arises.

Three thinkers associated with postcolonialism are Homi Bhabha (close to Foucault and Lacan), Gayatri Spivak (close to Foucault and Derrida), and Edward Said (close to Foucault). They explain colonial constructions and theorising that attributed such qualities as cunning and indolence to those who had been colonised.

Raymond Williams's cultural studies demonstrate the relationship between literature and economic conditions. New Historicism compares the textuality of history with the historicity of texts.

Elaine Showalter identifies the psychological, biological, and linguistic characteristics of women's writing. Simone de Beauvoir regards class and caste as impediments to women's commitment to women, a view opposed by later feminist theory. Virginia Woolf considers economic independence and privacy essential for women writers; her position was not considered revolutionary. Mary Wollstonecraft emphasised a revolution in women's education and the teaching of reason.

New Criticism: Eliot opposed the dominance of emotion in poetry and called for its impersonality. Improving the public's taste is also a critic's

task. Wimsatt and Beardsley argued that criticism should not rest on the poet's intention or historical study. Nor should it be based on the emotional effect upon the reader, since that is relative. It should rest on the actual words of the text.

The beginnings of English criticism can be traced to Philip Sidney, who considered poetry in relation to beauty, meaning, and human welfare.

John Dryden considered moral instruction in ancient literature and weighed its advantages and disadvantages.

Samuel Johnson wrote about the comic and tragic elements in Shakespeare's plays.

Rousseau's Romanticism does not doubt the goodness of human beings (classical critics do doubt it, while neoclassical critics hold that human nature is corrupted but institutions can improve it). At the same time, Romanticism maintains that institutions are corrupt and assist only corrupt people. It holds that poetry arises from personal experience.

Structuralism challenged modern positivism, which had placed no question mark over literature's given position; subsequently, the author lost the exclusive right to analyse his own written text.

Poststructuralism argues that literature exceeds what structuralism can comprehend. Postmodernism is one form of poststructuralism. It holds that structures operate among culture and theory in literature, where certain feelings and thoughts remain excluded and resist continuity. Deconstruction and postmodernism followed poststructuralism. Postcolonialism rejects new forms of colonialism, while the theory of disorder regards failed purposes as failing to secure their proper results.

Structuralism attacks repressive Western institutions and society, thereby strengthening Marxism (Althusser).

After modernist positivism, New Criticism, structuralism, and poststructuralism came deconstruction and postmodernism, which have been called the culture of late capitalism (Fredric Jameson).

In the eighteenth century, *modern* meant rootless; by the beginning of the twentieth century it had acquired a progressive meaning. After 1970, the word *modern* took on the character of a theory, and *postmodern* became a technical term under which the worldly ceased to be important. The life and history of the modern era were rendered insignificant and declared finished. This became a theory of the posthistorical, the postdevelopmental, and the postcausal. Truth and mutual connectedness lost their importance.

Magical realism introduces magical things into situations grounded in reality. Gabriel García Márquez's *One Hundred Years of Solitude* and

Salman Rushdie's *Midnight's Children* are novels of this kind. Writers employ such experiments in an effort to understand reality more fully.

Joseph Conrad calls the novel history. Conrad, whose mother tongue was Polish, became a celebrated novelist in English, although he did not speak English fluently. Roland Barthes says that the novel is history and also opposes history. Barthes was a French literary theorist whose writings influenced structuralist, Marxist, and poststructuralist literary theory.

Postmodern Western bourgeois culture uses audiovisual media to treat inequality, injustice, and deprivation as mere words, juxtaposed with the words equality, attainment, and justice. Poverty, which is not regarded as a problem in the West, remains a major problem in India today. Postmodernism opposes feminism and Marxism, and both feminism and Marxism have opposed it. Marxism, with its commitment to historical analysis, has renewed and strengthened its theory in relation to structuralism, poststructuralism, and postmodernism. Marxism stresses the material world, yet this does not make it identical with utilitarianism or Cārvāka philosophy, because those are concerned only with physical needs. Feminist thought likewise challenges the acceptance of the status quo in postmodernism: unless that condition is ended, women's position will not improve.

A bronze statuette found in the civilisation of Mohenjo-daro suggests a posture of dance, resembling the *thāṭ* posture of present-day Kathak: the right hand held at an angle of forty-five degrees, the left hand resting on the left hip, and the left leg slightly bent. According to the *Śāṅkhāyana Brāhmaṇa* of the *Rgveda*, singing, instrumental music, and dance were performed together. The *Aitareya Brāhmaṇa* counts all three among the divine arts. In *Rgveda* 10.76.6, the golden radiance of dawn reminds the poet of an adorned seer. The *Rgveda* also mentions communal dancing (*prāñco agāma nṛtaye*). The Soma sacrifice called *Mahāvrata* describes collective dancing by female servants, numbering three to six. *Śāṅkhāyana* 1.11.5 says that at weddings four to eight married women were given liquor and urged to dance four times. Vedic literature also refers to the bride's singing as part of the marriage rite. At the *sīmantonnayana* ceremony, the husband requests a vīṇā-player to sing accompanied music in praise of the deity Soma. The *Atharvaveda* connects the dance of the deity Vasā with ṛc, sāman, and gāthā, describing Gandharvas as present at the Soma-drinking dance. *Atharvaveda* 12.1.41 describes the combined sound of song, instrumental performance, and dance. Alongside Sāma music, secular musical forms known as *gāthā* and *nārāśaṃsī* were also current in the Vedic age.

Women: the *Rgveda* describes twenty-one female seers, among them Apālā, Ghoṣā, Śraddhā, Śacī, Sārparājñī, Yamī, Vaivasvatī, Devajāmaya,

Indrāṇī, Śaśvatī, Romaśā, Godhā, Urvaśī, Sūryā, Aditi, Nadī, Lopāmudrā, Viśvavārā, Vāk-Juhū, Saramā, and Yamī. *Devatā* means the subject being expounded, not 'God', as Griffith rendered it. In interpreting mantras, Maharshi Patañjali's methodological statement, "*yac chabda āha tad asmākaṃ pramāṇam*," means that what the word or the words of a mantra say is evidence for us. It was subsequently misinterpreted as meaning that the Veda alone is authoritative evidence.

Plato: he maintains that no art can be good because all art is false and unreal. His view should also be considered in relation to his perception of the weaknesses of Athens's military organisation compared with Sparta. He opposed poetry and drama insofar as the memorisation and recitation of dialogue might attract people towards an artificial life.

Aristotle does not regard poetry as imitation alone; he also finds philosophy and universal truth in it. He considers the tragic form of drama and its imitation a release or exhalation that comes after pleasure, pity, and fear.

Dialogue can take two forms, a formal address or ordinary conversation; conversation contains fewer philosophical elements. In ancient Greece, poetry was thought to convey a message from God. Aristophanes distinguishes good and bad poetry, while Theophrastus distinguishes severe, excellent, and magnificent poetry. Poetry and music are inseparable. The European symphony, however, in which many instruments play simultaneously in different rhythms, introduced a difference in theory. These considerations came to apply to the dramatic stage as well.

Derrida's method of deconstruction brings works and writers who have occupied high positions down, while raising those previously kept low. Roland Barthes writes that a work becomes important when it separates from its creator and can be analysed independently. He calls this the death of the author.

Poststructuralism overturned structuralism's assumption of completeness and coherent organisation. Saussure's theory of language distinguishes speaking and writing, the vocabulary of literature in its own time and historical context, the importance of the work or the person, and significance as an idea situated in language and its historical context. Derrida's deconstructive theory, however, began overturning these distinctions as well.

Sex is a biological fact, but the concept of woman and man is a social product. Literature and art concerned with women have been created by men, who view women through a male perspective. Feminist literary theory examines the roots of this problem. In the context of Mithila, women's condition has not been quite so bad; nevertheless, the one-sided

tendencies of Maithili literature have presented the suffering of upper-class women. Modernisation has also brought deterioration in the position of women among castes regarded as socially lower. Another consideration is that caste and religion have divided women's rights into several portions.

Feminist criticism also argues that, because theories have largely been constructed by men, they cannot provide a complete explanation. Simple humanism arose in opposition to theory, but it too became a theory. Meaningful literature was produced under its influence.

Excessive condemnation should be avoided in book reviews. Reviewers must refrain from showing off their learning; in the course of excessive criticism, people begin displaying their erudition. Restraint is essential, and abusive language exposes the reviewer's poor upbringing. Reviewing a book without reading it is unethical. For example, in *Karmadhāraya*, Taranand Viyogi writes about Dhumketu: "His story 'Namāz-e-Śukrānā' is very important in delineating the communal harmony that has been established in Mithila's culture for ages" (*Karmadhāraya*, p. 127). (!) Such a review has evidently been written after looking at the title, for in the story, during Haji Saheb's prayers, a parrot in a cage cries "Sita ... Ram ...". Haji Saheb repeatedly dashes the cage against the mosque wall until the parrot dies. Saeeda begins to cry, and the story ends. Yet, according to the reviewer, this story illustrates communal harmony!

A reviewer must also avoid excessive praise. The review should demonstrate how the book differs from others written on the same subject, what gap it fills, what it contains, and how it compares with those other books. Depending on the length of the work, a review may extend from one thousand to two thousand words. It should review the book, not its author. Filling a review with analyses of the author's other writings does not constitute a good review; those writings should be used only when directly relevant to the book under consideration. Given Mithila's diverse history and culture—and the particularly one-sided condition of Maithili literature—personal attacks and considerations of district and locality have become part of a tradition. Caste, religion, and regional forms of Maithili enter reviews comparatively little, but reviewers are profoundly influenced by the desire to praise or disparage someone because of their district, home area, or neighbouring locality.

Ask whether a particular review actually illuminates the book, or merely comments on its author and the author's other works. Closer scrutiny will reveal whether the reviewer has read the book at all. Avoid decorative verbal display, use words precisely, and remove unnecessary words and lines. In reviewing an autobiography, one may legitimately discuss the writer's life. Move beyond comments on the book's appearance, colours, and cover photograph to the book itself. Keep out anti-woman prejudices

and mentalities constrained by caste and region. Avoid pointless scrutiny of an author's name or the image on the cover.

The creation of an atmosphere in which an author tells a story is one component of the novel: this includes descriptions of its characters, the outline of the narrative, and the people and circumstances required for it. A story can be written from any one of these aspects. Drama combines emotionally charged dialogue with action. Poetry must create pictures through words and render them capable of stirring people's emotions; for this, apt suggestions that intervene in the poet's milieu, and a contribution from the science of sound, are also needed.

A reviewer must identify both what makes a work excellent and what it lacks. The evaluation must not be one-sided. The reviewer should understand and explain the message concealed in it and the direction in which the author is guiding the reader. A further question arises: how should one review a book of literary reviews? The reviewer must identify the book's central current of thought.

If a collection of criticism or essays contains many different kinds of essays and reviews and writings about numerous authors, the reviewer should determine whether the arrangement has a purpose or is purposeless.

As far as possible, a review should also discuss other books on the subject. One's ideology must not be imposed upon the book being reviewed. Explain the book's need and relevance in the present; show where its importance lies and identify its principal elements. Identify the author's philosophy of life, views of the relationship among the actual, the imaginary, and the ideal, and points of uncertainty. Discuss the artistic dimensions of the writing style, the capacity to tell a story, the design of the work, and the skill with which its different parts have been joined. One carpenter makes a bed that is both strong and beautiful; another concentrates on strength alone, while a third concentrates on beauty. Literary craftsmanship varies in the same way.

Why do we need theory? Simple humanism says that, instead of literary theory, common sense is sufficient to determine a work's humane outlook and whether it possesses significance. One can use one's own intelligence to judge the quality of writing; literary theory is not indispensable to criticism. Yet simple humanism itself became a theory.

Indian conceptions of poetry: the idea of art as a means towards liberation. Consider the posture of Naṭarāja, where the rhythms of creation and destruction are both visible. A permanent emotion becomes concentrated and ripens into *rasa*. How many such *rasas* did Sita and Rama experience? See the *Vālmīki Rāmāyaṇa*. Krishna is the teacher of the Indian philosophy of action, but he is also a connoisseur of aesthetic enjoyment.

The theory of *rasa* was needed to account for the enjoyment of art, and Bharata wrote the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Abhinavagupta wrote a commentary on Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka*. Bhāmaha in the sixth century, Daṇḍin in the seventh, and Rudraṭa in the ninth developed these discussions further.

The Theory of Rasa

Bharata: *Rasa* arises from the effect of drama. What is the purpose of drama? It is both to enact *rasa* and to bring it into being. How does *rasa* emerge? From its determinants (*vibhāva*), its consequences or visible responses (*anubhāva*), and associated transitory states (*vyabhicāri-bhāva*). A durable emotion becomes concentrated and ripens into *rasa*, which we can savour.

Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa: A permanent emotional state becomes concentrated through cause and effect and turns into *rasa*. Actors experience *rasa* through inquiry and imagination. Lollaṭa does not give importance to the poet or to the listeners and spectators.

Śaunaka: For aesthetic experience, Śaunaka considers it necessary for the spectator to enter into the performance and experience *rasa*, much as one appreciates a picture of a horse by apprehending it as a horse.

Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka: The effect of *rasa*, he argues, falls upon the spectator. He regards poetic language as distinctive. Through *rasa*, the soul of the listener or spectator is united with the supreme self. The bliss of *rasa* is the bliss of one's true nature; this brings self-realisation.

Rasa theory is founded upon the listener, spectator, and reader; it emphasises their experience.

In the context of structuralism and poststructuralism, Barthes regards the death of the author as necessary to free readers from the author's intentions: the author is separated from the work, and readers search for meaning for themselves.

The Theory of Dhvani

Ānandavardhana, in the *Dhvanyāloka*, holds that literature aims to communicate or create meaning indirectly. His theory explains the structure and operation of suggested meaning, *rasa* as an experience of beauty, and figures of speech. Ānandavardhana considers *dhvani* the soul of poetry. Meaning emerges indirectly through suggestion, but does so in an organised manner. From this arise two principles, meaning and symbol, and the effect of *rasa* is produced. Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā objected to this doctrine, arguing that *dhvani* has no independent existence but results from inference and is already included within secondary signification. Not everything can be described through words.

The Theory of Sphoṭa

Bhartṛhari's *Vākyapadīya* says that the meaning of a word or sentence is conveyed through *sphoṭa*. Letters emerge through *varṇa-sphoṭa*, words through *pada-sphoṭa*, and sentences through *vākya-sphoṭa*. No cognition is possible without a relationship to words. This became part of the Indian philosophical theory of knowledge. Meaning can be communicated without the simultaneous production of letters, words, and sentences. *Sphoṭa* is *śabda-brahman*, the word as ultimate reality and the fundamental cause of creation. Letters, words, and sentences do not exist simultaneously. The separate sounds of a spoken word do not individually contain its meaning; they are produced and disappear until the word is complete. Meaning is communicated through *sphoṭa*, although letters, words, and sentences are not all present at the instant at which *sphoṭa* is apprehended or communicated. Letters become meaningful one by one as the word reaches completion, just as words acquire significance in sequence until a sentence is complete. Sāṃkhya, Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā, and Vedānta reject *sphoṭa*: these systems hold that letters and their sounds adequately complete meaning. The deconstruction and dissemination associated with the French thinker Jacques Derrida are close to the theory of *sphoṭa*.

The Theory of Alaṃkāra

Bhāmaha treats *alaṃkāra* as compressed expression (*samāsokti*) that produces delight. Daṇḍin and Udbhaṭa also developed the theory of ornamentation. Broadly, there are two kinds of ornament: those based on words and those based on meaning. Further classifications rest upon resemblance and contrast, logic and justice, popular conventions, poetic conventions, and the perception of concealed meaning. Mammaṭa arranges sixty-one figures of speech in seven groups: *upamā* (simile), *rūpaka* (metaphor), *aprastuta* (indirect praise), *dīpaka* (distributed ornamentation), *vyatireka* (the demonstration of difference), *virodha* (opposition), and *samuccaya* (combination).

The Theory of Aucitya

In the *Aucityavicāracarcā*, Kṣemendra regards propriety as the principal element of literature. Where must such appropriateness be found? In words, sentences, the meaning of a composition, qualities, figures of speech, *rasa*, case relations, verbs, gender, number, adjectives, prefixes, particles, time, country, lineage, vows, fundamental principles, *sattva* or inward qualities, intention, temperament, the gathering of essentials, genius, condition, thought, names, and benedictions.

This universe trembles; it is nothing but vibration. After a poem has been recited, peace spreads—peace everywhere—and peace enters the mind.

Fiction and short-short fiction differ from the English-language short story and from the categories used in Maithili. Here, a story shorter than one page is *laghukathā*; a longer narrative of four or five to fifteen or twenty pages is a story or long story. The novel begins at roughly fifty or sixty pages.

Maithili-serving institutions founded principally upon Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas organise Vidyapati festivals, establish associations, and distribute prizes. Participation by those outside these two groups is limited, although it is now growing, which is a welcome sign for Maithili. The number of writers and readers belonging to other communities has also increased. In the modern information society, the media and the educational system have intervened in ways that resemble an assault upon Maithili language and Mithila culture. Fortunately, television channels such as Mithila, and Nepal's Kantipur FM, Janaki FM, and Radio Mithila have resisted that assault to a limited extent. The production of children's literature has grown as well. The Internet, too, has intervened in Maithili literature, though in a one-sided manner.

Discussion: A comparative study of Indian and Western dramatic theory reveals how much human thought can have in common despite geographical distance. Indian dramaturgy rests principally on Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* and Dhanañjaya's *Daśarūpaka*; the authoritative Western work is Aristotle's *Poetics*.

Bharata describes drama as an imitation of action and of emotion, while Dhanañjaya defines it as the imitation of a condition or situation. In Indian literary theory, imitation is the work of the actor, not of the poet. In the West, imitation is regarded as the poet's task, and the actor receives no comparable discussion.

Aristotle places particular emphasis on plot. Tragedy comprises plot, characterisation, diction, thought, spectacle and song. Bharata distinguishes the *ādhikārika* plot, which concerns the protagonist, from the *prāsaṅgika* or subsidiary story that assists it. Not every play, however, must have a subsidiary plot. In *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, neither a conventional principal plot nor a subsidiary one can be identified, since there is no universally acknowledged protagonist. The character who seizes a street ruffian by the collar soon recedes into the background. The ruffian before whom a thief stands submissively subsequently emerges to discourse on the philosophy that nothing new ever happens. Yama, before whom everyone trembles, finds his own authority diminished in the presence of Nibha. The beggar-woman laughs as his divine appearance is stripped away, while Ramani Mohan and Nibha eventually abuse both him and Chitragupta. The leftist and the actor fare much the same way. None of

the characters is simply weak; each rebounds in response to time and circumstance.

From the standpoint of the source of the action, the story may be *prakhyāta* (well known), *utpādya* (invented), or *miśra* (mixed). The first is taken from history or the Purāṇas, the second is imagined, and the third combines both. In *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, the possibility that the action is mixed disappears altogether when Chitragupta and Yama remove their false disguises and, as the beggar-woman laughs, Bhṛṅgī says that she too is a performer like themselves. Names such as Yama and Chitragupta do not, by themselves, make a story historical or Purāṇic: the action here is wholly invented. Aristotle divides plots into simple and complex. Because unexpected happenings flow so naturally into the action, this play may, by that classification, be called a work with a simple plot. Aristotle also relates narrative material to fable, invention and history; on those terms the play belongs to the imaginative category. The characters of Aristotelian tragedy are distinguished and noble, combining good and evil. In *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, too, good and evil are mixed in every character. Nibha is of high birth, yet she becomes intimate with Ramani Mohan, who dies after being beaten following a rape. The beggar-woman is Anasuya, a Mithila painter. Yet the two gentlemen, the street ruffian and the four soldiers appear without such moral stains. Bharata calls the lover of dance and music *dhīralalita*, the tranquil figure *dhīrapraśānta*, the one with a warrior's disposition *dhīrodātta*, and the jealous person *dhīroddhata*. The street ruffian and the two gentlemen are great lovers of music; Ramani Mohan is jealous at the sight of lovers. The soldiers are calm yet have the qualities appropriate to warriors, and thus are both *dhīrodātta* and *dhīrapraśānta*. But such divisions cannot be applied consistently to *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*.

Indian theory describes five stages of action: beginning, effort, hope of attainment, certainty of attainment, and achievement of the result. At the stage of hope, despair about obtaining the desired outcome intervenes; at the stage of certainty, hope returns. Western theory describes an opening, development of action, climax, falling action and final outcome. Entanglement develops in the first three stages and is resolved in the final two.

The five constituents through which action develops are *bīja* (seed), *bindu* (connecting point), *patākā* (extended subsidiary plot), *prakarī* (episodic subsidiary incident), and *kārya* (the completed action). The seed of *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* is a contradiction in the world after death: an insurance agent reaches it without dying. Yama and Chitragupta turn out to be make-up artists. Through successive connecting points, characters rise and fall in importance. *Patākā* and *prakarī* belong to subsidiary

narratives and are absent here. The mature form of the seed is *kārya*, but in this play the action ends in a sit-in protest. Aristotle calls the corresponding components beginning, middle and end. Consider now the *sandhis*, or dramatic junctures: *mukha-sandhi* joins the seed to the beginning; *pratimukha-sandhi* joins the connecting point to effort; *garbha-sandhi* joins the subsidiary plot to hope of attainment; *vimarśa-sandhi* joins the subsidiary incident to certainty of attainment; and *nirvahaṇa-sandhi* joins fulfilment of the result to the completed action. In *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, only *mukha*, *pratimukha* and *nirvahaṇa* are present; the other two junctures are absent.

Western theory seeks unity of place, time and action. In *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, the place remains the same, time proceeds continuously, and the action consists in the desire to gain admission through a gate. The events depicted in this two-hour play occupy two hours; the action, too, is single. Abhinavagupta maintains that one act should not contain more than one day's action, and that two acts should not contain events extending beyond a year. The division into *kallolas* in *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* arises from actions occurring at specified times and the delay before a fresh action begins. Dryden, however, opposed the three unities and defended the freedom of Shakespeare's plays. No such difficulty arises here. Conversations among the characters—which may also be called flashbacks —effectively show how each of them died.

In India the visual and performative nature of drama was upheld, whereas Aristotle and Plato opposed it. In the sixteenth century, however, Lodovico Castelvetro defended spectacle. Dittetart, too, supported the visual aspect, while Dryden upheld the readability of plays. Dacier supported both reading and performance. Abhinavagupta had likewise said that the full enjoyment of *rasa* comes after a work has been acted, although reading can also yield that enjoyment. At the beginning of the first *kallola* of *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, it becomes clear that primacy has been given to performance. Western theatrical convention tends towards realistic representation; the Indian stage uses suggestion and symbol. Thus in Kālidāsa's *Abhijñānaśākuntalam* the stage direction says, *iti śarasaṃdhānaṃ nāṭayati*—'he acts the fitting of an arrow'. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* adopts the Indian convention: the invisible wall at heaven's entrance is made intelligible through the conversations and acting of those who have died. The performative element was prominent in *Aṅkiyā Nāṭ*, too. The *Kīrtaniyā* tradition was musical, yet acting was central there also; an *Aṅkiyā* performance began with the playing of the *mṛdaṅga*. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* connects itself to Maithili tradition while offering a new perspective on history, mythology and the cycles of contemporary life, and a fresh insight with which to think about them.

The dramatic succession runs through Jyotirīśvara's *Dhūrtasamāgama*, Vidyāpati's *Gorakṣavijaya*, *Kīrtaniyā* theatre, *Aṅkiyā Nāṭ*, Munshi Raghunandan Das's *Mithilā Nāṭak*, Jīvan Jha's *Sundar Saṃyog*, Īśnāth Jha's *Chīnīk Laḍḍū*, Govind Jha's *Basāt*, Maṇipadma's *Tesar Kaniyā*, Nachiketa's *Nāyakak Nām Jīvan, Ek Chal Rājā*, Shrishji's *Puruṣārtha*, Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary's *Bhapāit Chāhak Jingī*, Mahendra Malangia's *Kāṭhak Lok*, Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar's *Mahiṣāsur Murdābād*, and Gangesh Gunjan's *Budhibadhiyā*. In extending this tradition, Nachiketa's *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* repeatedly rejects the rationality and presumed objectivity of modernity. Yama even tells the leftist that what he sees is not necessarily true; it might be a dream. The play questions the completeness of scientific knowledge. Truth and falsehood are described from each person's point of view. The thief has his own argument, while the leftist says that a thief cannot become a leader, yet when a leader takes to stealing the thief's profession is threatened. The play displays self-centred humour, while distinctions between good and bad repeatedly dissolve. Even Yama and Chitragupta live behind masks. Alongside these postmodern traits, multiple and different characters emerge from the same person, as in the case of the high-born woman. No event yields a complete meaning, and one never knows when truth will turn into falsehood. The play seems crowded with the superficial thought and characters of postmodernity. There is certainly no optimism, but neither is there pessimism: what remains is a kind of madness. Nothing can be considered in only one way; several ways of thinking coexist. Instead of faith in consequences arising from causes, control and plans, the play shows greater faith in outcomes produced by coincidence. Democratic and feminist perspectives, the red flag, and other ideological symbols are objects of laughter and playful mockery.

Thus *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* presents a postmodern outlook in which readers encounter various problems raised within the dramatic action. The contradiction displayed at its end does not astonish a reader of the postmodern age, for that reader confronts similar contradictions every day.

Review of a Short-Story Collection

In most of the stories in Subhash Chandra Yadav's collection *Banait Bigarait* (*Making and Unmaking*), one finds that the narrative advances with a theme rather than merely telling an anecdote, and ends as soon as its work has been accomplished. Its second distinguishing quality is its language. The language of *Balchanma* is the autobiographical speech of that novel's central character, whereas here the language belongs to the

storyteller himself; in that sense, it acquires a distinctive form. On the one hand, Yadav's stories resist the convention by which storytelling becomes a didactic tale, maintain the theme within a limited compass, and attend to a thoroughly indigenous linguistic craft. These combined qualities will give one section of readers immense pleasure. On the other hand, readers who have not yet moved beyond anecdotal tales will not be disappointed by the collection; rather, it will refine their taste.

Some questions of linguistic standardisation arise, for example the forms 'ऐछ', 'अछि' and 'अ इ छ'. These needed attention when standardisation was taking place. One might, for instance, write 'जाति रही' instead of 'जाइत रही', then formulate a rule for pronouncing 'जाति' as 'जा इ त'; the issue of 'ऐछ' and 'अछि' is similar. It is rather late now. The author himself points towards a solution through his usage in *Kaniyā-Putarā*, yet reverts to another form in his other stories. This makes the need to settle on a standard form all the clearer. If one writes 'छै', that is acceptable; if one writes 'छैक', a pronunciation rule must establish that the final 'क' is silent. The need is for an early and generally accepted settlement. People today do not have a lifetime to argue whether one should write 'य' or 'ए'. Follow phonetic principles, or frame explicit rules of pronunciation. Writing 'नञि' for 'नहि' can be understood, but among 'नइँ' (*Antikā*), 'नइं' (NBT), and 'नँइ' (Saketanand, *Kālarātriśca Dāruṇā*), Saketanand's usage is more appropriate according to phonetics. If this is doubted, consult a phonetics laboratory. (An audio file of the scientific and standard Maithili alphabet is available for listening to or downloading through the Videha Audio link in the Videha archive, http://www.videha.co.in/.)

An important feature of *Banait Bigarait* is therefore Yadav's particular phonetic writing practice, which can advance the debate on standardisation.

The journey of the story extends through Vedic narratives, Jātaka tales, Aesop's fables, the *Pañcatantra* and the *Hitopadeśa*, alongside the continuing folk ballads. Folk narrative exists everywhere beside the stories of the elite.

The prospect of failure is greater for a short story than for a novel, epic or extended narrative, because a novel resembles a 'soap opera' that proceeds for months or years, each episode ending at some point of suspense. A

novel of seventy episodes can sustain hope through sixty-nine of them that the story will take a turn; even if nothing changes by the end, all the earlier episodes are hits and only the final episode is a flop. A short story grants no such allowance. It is a work of one episode: if it is good, it is very good; otherwise, it is simply bad.

Moving beyond narrative and ballad, the history of the modern short story begins in the late nineteenth century. Its forms came to be described as the very short story, the story, and fiction, though the distinctions among the three have also been explained at unnecessary length. Beginning with Rabindranath Tagore, this journey advanced across India as a consequence of reformist movements. Bezbarua in Assamese, Fakir Mohan Senapati in Odia, Apparao in Telugu, and Kedarnath Banerjee in Bengali all appeared, sometimes in support of women and sometimes against the usurers of society. In Nepali, Suryakant Gyaawali wrote 'Devīko Bali' against the practice of animal sacrifice during Dussehra. Some stories opposed barriers of caste and wealth to love; others explored the condition of Dalit society and religious superstition. Nor did these stories invariably end happily.

Ideologies and literature: postmodernism, existentialism and humanism are all philosophical schools of thought. Earlier, philosophy included science, history, society and politics, economics, the arts and language. As the branches of science and the arts, particularly science, acquired specialisation, philosophy moved towards mathematics, mathematical logic, and analytical methods of induction and deduction. Marx, who was like a divine intervention for the poor throughout the world, made the dialectical method the basis of his interpretation. What we now call 'discussion' or debate, bringing both sides of an argument together, was already present in the method of refutation and defence of philosophical positions, especially in the six systems of Indian philosophy (see Mādhavācārya's *Sarvadarśanasaṃgraha*).

Francis Fukuyama, who proclaimed the end of history after the fall of communist government, later withdrew from that position. Postmodernism, too, has faltered after its initial enthusiasm. Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, Romanticism and sociological analysis have all survived by becoming part of synthetic approaches to criticism. Psychoanalysis, grounded in scientific inquiry, will survive like the dialectical method.

What is a modern short story? What should it be like? Does it have a purpose, or ought it to have one? And how can that purpose be determined?

Psychology can also provide a foundation for a story. Its purpose should change with society's needs, and the changing journey of storytelling should correspond to changes occurring in society. Yet the story is, at the same time, inevitably conditioned by the culture of that society, through which its historical existence becomes visible.

If we speak of Vedic narratives, they bring out love for the nation and teach people to live together in society. The Jātaka tales seek not only the spread of popular language but also the dissemination of Buddhism. The tales of the Muslim world include Rumi's *Masnavi*, a distinguished work of Persian literature that teaches the importance of knowledge and the advancement of the state. Stories today encompass these purposes and move towards the creation of an enlightened and humane (!) society. Where that is not the case, it ought to become part of their purpose. Only then can the analysis and criticism of a story become a compelling necessity for the reader.

After communist rule ended and the Berlin Wall fell, Francis Fukuyama declared that history, created by clashes among ideologies, had reached its end and that only an ideology working for human welfare would advance. Later he retreated from that judgment, saying that many different ideologies continued to survive within societies and between national identities. Similarly, the postmodern thinker Jacques Derrida deconstructed language to show that its divided parts rest on numerous different foundations, and that we cannot establish meaning without understanding them.

Like psychoanalysis and dialectics, the analyses of Fukuyama and Derrida will remain enduring models for criticism through processes of synthesis.

Subhash Chandra Yadav's Short-Story Collection *Banait Bigarait*: Yadav belongs to the generation of storytellers after independence. Through fiction he gives form to life. He endows stories with both craft and substance, making them meaningful. It is only natural that his stories should reveal the struggle of ordinary people for existence. Perhaps Badariya, in his story 'Kāṭhak Banal Lok', written several decades ago, was laughing by coincidence. The characters in the present collection have comparable peculiarities. In a hospital one character wakes after crying himself to sleep and begins crying again; another has fallen in love. Some possess business sense, while a character like Harivansh does harm in return for a good deed because of a system fault.

For Whom Should We Write—or Tell—Stories? Ideologies of Fiction

Those about whom we write will not read what we write. Will reading stories make people enlightened? There is no shortage of people who swear by the *Gītā* and then tell lies. Does the importance of a story written with such a criterion in mind thereby diminish?

Even if everyone does not become enlightened, they can at least enjoy wholesome entertainment. If just one person reads a story and begins to think in that direction, the story has demonstrated its value. Even if those for whom the story was written do not read it, people who are able to intervene in their circumstances will do so. As long as that possibility remains, stories of this kind will continue to be written.

If society changes, will social values remain eternal? Should progressive fiction reconstruct experience for a changing society, bringing natural and social realities into adjustment with one another? Or does a changing age need stories based on the enduring, essential elements of tradition, so that it may acquire stability? There is a duality between individual and social interests, and the two often oppose one another. They must be brought into relation. A world-view is essential. Fiction is not merely a thought produced and transferred haphazardly from ink to paper; it is directed by social and historical conditions.

Should a story, then, be idealistic, naturalistic or realistic? Should it instead be humanistic, socialistic or a sensory realism that accords importance to experience? Or should it be purposive? This last outlook includes utilitarianism, experimentalism, pragmatism, causalism, instrumentalism and consequentialism. It is the most modern perspective. Self-expression is part of human nature, but it is restricted by social rules and affected by circumstances.

A story should therefore be fashioned through a reconstruction of experience. Individual consciousness will then become social and collective consciousness. The exploiter will have to curb his own tendencies, and the exploited will have to resist them openly.

Freedom—social change. Only then will the story communicate; it will become a means of dialogue. Only then can fiction become a weapon for society, a source of strength.

If the storyteller preaches, he merely transfers knowledge, and that is no longer what is needed. When the storyteller begins a dialogue, an atmosphere of liberation becomes possible, and readers who participate in that dialogue are freed from inertia.

The story must be sequential and accessible to achieve this purpose. It must become practical rather than merely intellectual. The openness of the narratives of Vedic literature gave rise to dialogue, which the rigidity of Purāṇic literature subsequently destroyed.

Restoring dialogue requires confidence in the storyteller—confidence based on argument and on experience—and Subhash Chandra Yadav possesses both. The analytical philosophy of positivism examines linguistic statements and concepts rather than objects. This is visible throughout Yadav's stories. Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism emerged as reactions to science; in this process, ambiguous scientific ideas were clarified.

Phenomenology studies what is given to consciousness precisely as it is given. Experience is the observation of the facts of particular mental acts, a means of seeing things disinterestedly and in their purity. In existentialism, the human being alone is the human being; one is nothing apart from what one creates and is condemned to be free, as Sartre says. Through Hegelian dialectics, emphasis falls on judging the nature and existence of processes through the endless interrelation of analysis and synthesis. The deeper the essential element, the further it is from external form and the closer to reality.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also influenced modern thinking. Behind visible reality, inner and outer processes become possible through exchanges among minute particles of force and energy. Under the principle of uncertainty, position and form must be determined approximately.

Imagining a world with more than three dimensions, together with Stephen Hawking's *A Brief History of Time*, directly undermines the existence of God, for it also brings the notion of God's death to the fore: the existence of the ruler of the universe is now endangered. In a perspective shaped by the death of God and the end of history, how long will Maithili fiction go on merely telling tales? How long will it remain absorbed in analysing the short-short story, the very short story, the story and fiction under their separate names?

Just as virtual reality presents reality artificially and fuses consciousness with it, so, unless we conceive more than three dimensions, we could begin travelling at the speed of light from the age of the Indus Valley civilisation and still not have crossed the universe today. This sun is one ordinary star —one mediocre star—among billions upon billions of others. We live on one of its planets, Earth, in some town or village, sitting with our hands

on our heads in anxiety and asking whose problem could be greater than our own. These scientific and philosophical facts confront our fiction as challenges.

A holistic synthesis, a coordination of totality, will be necessary! Only then will philosophy move from the merely philosophical to the real.

Poststructuralist methodology derives linguistic meaning not simply from words, their meanings, or the rules of grammar, but from the process through which meaning is produced. It assumes different meanings for different individuals and groups. There is no final relation between language and the world; neither words nor their texts possess a final or single, uniquely fixed meaning.

Modernity arose from modern and postmodern arguments, reality, dialogue and exchanges of ideas. But then New Left movements appeared in France, alongside ideologies such as nihilism and anarchism. These arose from distrust of the beliefs and assumptions of the modern system of thought.

Hidden meanings in texts began to be interpreted in relation to time and place; language came to be treated as a game—a language game. Postmodernism emerged as a critique of power, legitimacy and the hierarchies of both.

In the computer and information revolution, a software developer creates a program and places it on the World Wide Web. The program continues working independently of its maker, sometimes doing things for which its maker did not design it. Other interfering programs, such as viruses, divert it and turn it destructive. An antivirus program is also software, designed to correct the problem; if even that cannot set matters right, the computer is backed up and formatted—a clean slate!

Capitalism was born with the Industrial Revolution. Now, in post-industrial society, the importance of information and communication has increased relative to production, and the role of the computer in society has expanded. Mobile phones, credit cards and similar objects are chip-based. During this year's (2008) Kosi floods, Analkantji was trapped in his village, struggling to obtain food, yet he was able to book an air-conditioned train ticket with a credit card. What better example could one require of information and computers in Mithila's society?

Deconstruction and reconstruction indicate a remaking of the processes by which thought is composed, as consciousness takes new forms in the post-

industrial age. History itself has not ended, but traditional history has. The state, class, nation, political party, society, family, morality and marriage are all being redefined. Many institutions have become fragmented and lost their contexts as a result of rapid change.

In this setting, let us take a close look at the history of the Maithili story. Ramdev Jha regarded Jaldhar Jha's 'Vilakṣaṇ Dāmpatya' (*Maithil Hit Sādhan*, Jaipur, 1906) as the beginning of the modern Maithili short story. Then came Pulkit Mishra's 'Mohinī Mohan' (1907–08), Janseidan's 'Tārāk Vaidhavya' (*Mithilā Mihir*, 1917), Shrikrishna Thakur's *Chandraprabhā*, Tulapati Singh's *Madanrāj Charit*, Kali Kumar Das's *Adalāk Badlā* and *Kāminīk Jīvan*, Shyamanand Jha's *Akiñchan*, Shri Ballabh Jha's *Vilāsitā*, Harinandan Thakur 'Saroj's *Īśvarīya Rakṣā*, Shardanand Thakur 'Vinay's *Tārā*, Shyam Sundar Jha 'Madhup's *Pratijñā-Patra*, Vaidyanath Mishra 'Vidyasindhu's *Gapp-Sappak Kharihān*, and Prabodh Narayan Singh's *Bīchal Phūl*. This journey was carried forward by Harimohan Jha's stories and Yatri's novellas; Rajkamal Chaudhary, Lalit, Ramdev Jha, Balram, Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary, Dhumketu, Rajmohan Jha, Saketanand, Vibhuti Anand, Sundar Jha 'Shastri', Dhirendra, Rajendra Kishore, Revati Raman Lal, Rajendra Vimal, Rambhadra, Ashok, Shivshankar Srinivas, Pradip Bihari, Ramesh, Maneshwar Manuj, Shyam Darihare, Kumar Pawan, Anmol Jha, Mithilesh Kumar Jha, Harishchandra Jha, Upadhyay Bhushan, Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Bhuvaneshwar Pathey, Badri Narayan Verma, Ayodhyanath Chaudhary, R. N. Sudhakar, Jitendra Jeet, Surendra Labh, Jaynarayan Jha 'Jigyasu', Shyam Sundar 'Shashi', Ramesh Ranjan, Dhirendra Premarshi, Parmeshwar Kapari, Taranand Viyogi, Nagendra Kumar, Amarnath, Devshankar Navin, Analkant, Shridharam, Nita Jha, Vibha Rani, Ushakiran Khan, Susmita Pathak, Shephalika Verma, Jyotsna Chandram and Lalpari Devi.

Is there no good fiction in Maithili? No good drama? Does Maithili have no grammar? Where is the grammatical analysis of forms such as *panisoh* and *panigar*, or of *anal* and *pāvak*? Yet Dinbandhu Jha's book on verbal forms contains 1,025 such indigenous forms, and Ramanath Jha's *Mithilābhāṣāprakāś* contains an authentic Maithili grammar. With these two reference books, the construction of a standard language and grammar is entirely possible. What happens instead is rather like writing, in an analysis of the First Battle of Panipat, that the battle was fought between Panipat and Babur. Dhirendra has described Rambhadra as the greatest Maithili short-story writer, but how many of his stories have actually been analysed so far? These questions had to be raised in relation to Nachiketa's drama, the work of Mahendra Malangia—the Shakespeare of Maithili—and the course of storytelling represented by Rambhadra and Subhash Chandra Yadav.

At a time when the central problem of Maithili is its expulsion from household after household, people who have tried their hand at Hindi without attaining recognition turn to Maithili stories and poems, become editors and critics, and weigh down the literary atmosphere with their ambitions. Marxism, feminism and secularism are thrust repeatedly into stories and poems, and these labels then serve to determine standards; ideology becomes a fence sheltering mediocrity. Those engaged in exploiting and discouraging the poor and people of lower castes seek refuge in Marxism; those who have insulted women take refuge in feminism, the demand for a Mithila state, and associations; and communalists take refuge in secularism. Communalists have also been seen among feminists, opponents of women among Marxists, and many such combinations within literary factions and establishments. One group praises Rajkamal, another Yatri or Dhumketu, another Sumanji, while advancing themselves under the cover of deciding which side these writers supposedly represent. 'Yatri's *Pāro* and the stories of Rajkamal and Dhumketu have still not been accepted'—such absurd pronouncements are made. Some editors produce collections of supposedly controversial stories, create the controversy themselves and use it for self-promotion. Competition confined largely to writing by Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas has unsettled these poets and storytellers; after leaving Hindi for Maithili, they perform these manoeuvres with such speed that one wonders when they will notice Maithili's principal problem. Do they believe that writing in Maithili after Hindi will win them immediate acceptance? If Maithili writers suffer such illusions and such a lack of confidence in the communicative power of their mother tongue (!), what pretence are we sustaining by entrusting the language's future to them? At seminars I am astonished to see such combative, Sahitya Akademi award-winning storytellers, editors and critics speaking with their own sons, daughters and wives not in Maithili but in Hindi (English usually being beyond their abilities). When there were twenty people writing in Maithili and five reading it, what controversy could have arisen? Having read the individual works of Rajkamal and Yatri, I can say that their Maithili writing is gentle in tone. Under such circumstances, why introduce the claim that 'this poem contained a controversy' or 'that story contained one', and then polish one's reputation by arguing for it? Next come pronouncements about the 'first novelist after Yatri' and the 'first poet after Rajkamal'; now pairs of poets and storytellers appear, devoted to one another and promoting their mutual ideological faction. Maithili's chief problem is that the language is dying under the weight of the competing ambitions of this limited and fiercely combative group. Poets and storytellers have turned Maithili into a career, excluded it from their homes, and made it an object of seminars. Where, then, are the readers, and what is this talk of controversy? Where

are the stories and poems that will help create a Maithili-speaking environment for children and encourage people of every caste to love the language? How many science stories, and how much literature and poetry for children and adolescents, are these careerist writers producing? What efforts are being made to bring such work into every home? In an atmosphere of printing a hundred or two hundred copies of a book, arranging its reviews, publishing in journals of a hundred or two hundred copies, making folders of photocopies to keep at home, and manipulating prizes and syllabus selections, my hope has come to rest with readers and writers outside the Maithil Brahmin–Karna Kayastha circle.

Those who could not manage their own households sit surrounded by language awards and busy themselves with creating a Mithila state. How they would govern a state, and in which language they would speak in its legislature when they came to receive an award there, I do not know.

People who do not speak Maithili at home have become writers and poets, equally at home in Hindi and Maithili; they think and write in Hindi, then translate the result and call it original Maithili writing! They call this Maithili fiction and poetry!

They shamelessly receive prizes for translations into Maithili from Marathi, Urdu, Tamil and Kannada. Ask them what *vaṇakkam* means: they cannot tell you. They do not know *alif, be, se*; they cannot speak in Marathi even with a child. They escape having their shortcomings exposed in Maithili because they have their own work printed and reviewed, while there are no readers. The absence of readers benefits them. And when jury members and advisory boards come forward to promote themselves through these prizes, the weakness of confidence among this small circle of competitors becomes plain. Sarang Kumar is there, and Balram has begun to be discussed once again as a storyteller. What of those writers whose children did not enter literature? Who will discuss them and present their case? While alive, everyone promotes his own position; but after death? These truths about Maithili literature must be brought into the open. Even with their eyes closed, people continue searching for a solution.

Becoming a Marxist or a feminist, turning even that into a trade, and making up for one's own inadequate literary stature in this fashion have become weapons for writers of little talent within a restricted competition. Why would anyone who respects Marx feel compelled to announce, 'I am a Marxist critic' or 'I am a Marxist writer'? But what can one say about those who trade in Marx? A trade has likewise developed around Suman, Rajkamal, Yatri, Manipadma, Dhumketu and others, and the reason is clear enough. National surveys show that those unable to secure admission

to other subjects end up studying Sanskrit, Hindi, Maithili and other literatures in college; the same people enter journalism. Such devotees of literature, impoverished in talent, have acquired a taste for it: will Maithili's future be safe in their hands? Yet alongside this reality, the road ahead awaits us. A generation of genuine workers for Maithili, storytellers and readers ready to go among the dust and dirt, writing literature for children and women and dedicating their energies simply to keeping Maithili alive, will certainly emerge.

The lack of firmness in the personal life of a storyteller or poet—whether towards an ideology, caste or religion—shows itself in the literature. Such writing may be revised and expanded time and again without escaping its fundamental fault. There is scope for literary blackmailers to use stories and poems for personal self-praise and attacks on others. Premshankar Singh, however, identifies this tendency through evidence-based evaluation. He identifies the casteism and communalism that enter the work; he also asks how literature afflicted by an inferiority complex can contribute to the common good. In Maithili literature, where the number of readers is virtually nil, one writer reviews another; personal ego and blackmail have ample scope. Attend a few conferences of poets and fiction writers: the announcer's introductions and the applause will reveal the prejudices of the announcer and the writers. In this context, this collection offers a new perspective. It maps one-sided presentations against changing social, economic, political and religious equations and distinguishes critical appraisal from mere gossip and talk.

Stratification within castes, disputes between castes, polygamy, child marriage and the *bikauā* system of marriage: there was not even a symbolic movement against child marriage or in favour of widow remarriage. The Śūdra poet Ailūṣa composed Vedic hymns, and society once possessed such strength that Alexander met fierce resistance from the confederation of the Śūdras. In Mithila, too, when its artisans and the people considered to occupy society's lower levels were strong, the name Janaka was derived from *jana*, 'the people'. There then emerged the chain of Simraungarh, Pajebagarh, Balirajpur Fort, Asurgarh Fort, Jaynagar Fort, Nandangarh, Katragarh, Naulagarh, Mangalgarh, Kichakgarh, Benugarh and Varijangarh as expressions of Mithila's architectural culture. These fortresses were in keeping with the name Mithila, a land that could crush its enemies. Buddhist caves and images of Tārā, among others, also reveal other forms of artisanal art. But as orthodoxy increased, Mithila was left with virtually no achievement in architecture. Economic conditions deteriorated until people were going without an evening meal. Migration checked starvation, but at a price. Similarly, scholars such as Maitreyī disappeared for a millennium because of caste rigidity, both differentiation within caste and divisions between castes. Education declined so far that,

although four of the six philosophical systems arose from Mithila, today entire villages are full of people who have not passed the matriculation examination.

The proletarian culture of the Maithils is passing through a revolutionary upheaval. Migration can be a good thing; but when, within one generation, village after village has been emptied, it becomes a curse for the culture concerned. Twenty per cent of Maithil culture lies in Nepal and eighty per cent in India. Migration has produced economic, social, political and cultural crises here.

Among the various prose genres—treatises, essays, criticism, stories and fiction, novels, epistolary literature, travel memoirs, reportage and others—stories, narratives and novels rest particularly on imagination blended with experience. They are closely related to what we call *khissā-pihānī*, the telling of tales. Stories, narratives and novels, and to some extent plays and one-act plays, are heard, told, read or performed for entertainment. They may have a purpose, or they may embrace purposelessness—absurdity—for even literature without an explicit purpose can entertain amid life's ceaseless rush.

The name *laghukathā* designates a genre that is, first and foremost, a story, and only then a short-short story. The short-short story, short story, longer story, novel, play and one-act play all rest on imagination enriched by experience. English, too, makes distinctions according to length—short story, novelette, novella and novel—which can be used respectively for *laghukathā*, *kathā*, *dīrgha kathā* and *upanyās*. The word counts of all these genres fluctuate more in Maithili than in English and other European languages, although in those languages too there is variation according to each writer's taste and the requirements of the subject. Similarly, the one-act play corresponds to *ekāṅkī*, and the full play to *nāṭak*.

A short-short story is, therefore, a story all the same.

Your imagination, mingled with experience, urges you to say something. What you have to say may take the form of a humorous miniature or a non-humorous miniature. People may tell you that you have an inexhaustible stock of anecdotes, that you are quick-witted. Emboldened by this, you shape that material in the mould of literary craft and make it into a short-short story.

The main difficulty with a humorous miniature is that the joke you tell will circulate and eventually come back to you: somewhere along the way its originality is lost. Such a miniature may range from a line or two to half a page or a page. It can be incorporated into a story or novel, but the short-short story does not allow it the same space. Yet what one does in a story or novel—placing the miniature in a character's mouth, or

connecting it with another incident so that it acquires meaning—can also be done in a short-short story. Fiction grows out of narrative; moral tales, inspirational stories and mystical tales also exist in forms ranging from brief to extended. It is not the case that their shorter forms cannot be short-short stories.

The rapid presentation of a thought often seen in the short-short story is also found in stories and novels. But the absence of an instantly presented thought does not disqualify a work from being a short-short story. Quite the contrary: when examining one, a critic should attend to its enduring elements, not merely its speed of presentation. Too great an inclination towards the instant thought turns it into a non-humorous miniature: it may still be a short-short story, but it will not be a distinguished one. The claim that a short-short story must strike the reader with a jolt in order to qualify as a story, or as a great story, is mistaken. It is perfectly reasonable to jot down a sudden thought lest it be forgotten. But before hastily making it into a short-short story, allow the idea to mature. Consider what might be combined with it so that it acquires an enduring quality. One may, of course, write a jolting short-short story without allowing the idea to mature, but its chances of becoming an outstanding work are slight. A flashy song does not necessarily retain its effect for long; similarly, we must ask whether this form of storytelling is becoming a kind of Twenty20 cricket.

A novel cannot be read in a single sitting, whereas a short story can. In one sitting, several short-short stories can be read. The novelist can describe setting, plot and character with a fullness unavailable to the short-story writer. A short story focuses on one aspect—or, one might say, one event —and in doing so can offer no more than a broad descriptive sketch of the setting and a person's life. A short-short story does not even permit this broad sketch; it provides too little room for it. Yet it too is centred on a single aspect or event. That aspect or event should be one that continually tempts the author to write it as an independent work, rather than destroy its independence by making it part of a story or novel.

The plot of a story will therefore be simpler than the plot of a novel; for a short-short story, even such a plot is not essential. Mould the description of an aspect or event through literary craft, and a complete short-short story is ready.

The Critical Theory of the Short-Short Story

How should a short-short story be reviewed? An imaginative narrative mixed with experience, extending from a line or two to a page and a half or two pages (and sometimes even five pages), may properly be called a *laghukathā*. If an entire story is told completely within such a small form, however, it will no longer be called a short-short story. Where a sequence

of events is required to convey the substance, the sequence must be complete, even if its links grow somewhat longer. Haste to produce an instant effect may weaken the sequence. Reversing the current at every turn and bringing in a sudden effect have become a formula for certain celebrated short-short-story writers. In one or two pieces, this may seem attractive, like an 'item song' in a film; thereafter, the critic notices the device, because it becomes reactive rather than proactive. It produces no lasting effect and reveals a limitation in the writer's talent. The best short-short story builds a sequence of events and leaves judgment to the reader. It has no room for prolonged explanation, but that does not mean the matter must be disposed of in two or four lines. If an author calls such a two- or four-line piece a short-short story, the critic must accept that classification, although the likelihood of its being an outstanding short-short story diminishes.

The subjects of the short-short story need not be confined to fleeting incidents from everyday life. Writers should also compose short-short stories for children, for moral education and on religious subjects. At present, much of the material comes only from travelling by train or bus or from conversations around the fire on the veranda at home. Social and economic problems could provide enduring subjects; political questions and natural disasters could also be addressed. A critic should not evaluate the genre as though it were the Purāṇic habit of saying that Śiva is supreme in the *Śiva Purāṇa* and Garuḍa in the *Garuḍa Purāṇa*. That is, one must not assume that whatever happens to be written automatically constitutes a short-short story. The novel gives a writer ample room to display the full range of talent; the short story offers less, and the short-short story less still. But by enlarging the range of subjects, writers can meet readers' demands. Stories and short-short stories can be strengthened by keeping dialogue to a minimum or placing it before an exposition; otherwise, they risk becoming one-act plays or full plays. A short-short story may be included in a story or novel, but inserting a humorous miniature into the short-short story ought to be avoided from the critical point of view. Space is already scarce, and if conversation and a joke are pushed into it as well, its effect will not endure.

A good short-short story will be judged not by the speed of its presentation but by the human values sharply expressed within it, its elements of social harmony, and the principles of social life founded upon equality and justice. We must ask whether it conveys, with equal sharpness, how society can advance on that basis. Does it free readers' minds from constraints? Does it endow them with the strength of character and self-confidence to lead others? Does it dispel doubts concerning moral development and respect for labour? All these will be standards of the short-short story. People on society's margins can achieve things beyond the power of the

privileged, but only when their self-confidence is strengthened. How can literature burdened with an inferiority complex serve the common good? One-sided representations must be identified against the changing equations of society, economics, politics and religion. The instability of the storyteller's or poet's personal life, whether in relation to ideology or caste and religion, becomes visible in the work. One must also recognise the feeling of superiority—another form of inferiority—that arises when exploiters write about their benefactions towards the exploited, or write out of guilt. Identify mediocrity: clichés and the passing 'breaking news' of the day presented in the name of modernity. Such writing cannot give us the ideas required to understand an age. Modernisation, democratisation, implementation of the nation-state, administrative and legal development, increased public participation, stability and the capacity for orderly change, the dynamics of power, industrialisation, the political, social, economic and cultural problems of new states after independence, and processes of change and integration are sometimes mutually contradictory. There are also the development of community, and psychological and educational processes.

Adivasi groups such as the Satar and Gidarmara reflect diversity and differing levels of development: closeness to nature, nature worship, simplicity, guilelessness and gratitude. A person's standing is based on place and caste. Some castes enjoy status and privilege; others face contempt and hard lives. In the development of women and children, attention must be given to women's rights, to activating the education system, to women's studies in the curriculum and to raising women's participation in vocational and technical education. There are women's liberation and women's movements. Secular political institutions ought to rest upon the economic and social interests of the entire community, without distinctions of religion, race or sect. If educational development precedes economic development, ordinary people can participate in the latter; their creative capacity grows, and they acquire a sense of responsibility.

Science and technology, the gulf between developed and undeveloped countries, and the human problems arising from that gulf—disease, ignorance and insecurity—raise questions of solutions, aspirations, hope, and the boundless expansion and foundations of material facilities. Law and order should be employed to deliver justice to poor and disadvantaged people. Civil liberties, democratic human rights, independent thought, the creation of a capable society, and freedom from restrictions and coercion must be defended. The press, as a link between rulers and ruled, has a role in social, economic and political life; powerful advertising agencies, however, now influence public opinion. New institutions must be established, or existing ones reformed, against feudal, tribal, caste and

sectarian loyalties: democracy, liberalism, republicanism, constitutionalism, socialism, egalitarianism, constitutional rights, regular popular elections, popular sovereignty, federal division of powers, the importance of public opinion, public-administrative processes and initiatives, the organisation of party interests, a supreme legislature, a responsible executive and an independent judiciary all belong here. Harmful changes in the physical, chemical and biological qualities of water, earth, air and the sky produce pollution and ecological imbalance.

Art: ought it to have any theoretical purpose? Art is an aestheticised presentation of the world. The art of beauty stands alongside utility; a philosophy of life and a tradition may be bound up with the ideal of artistic completeness. The emotional atmosphere involves the aesthetic perception of truth and artistic activity, the beautiful and the concrete, the abstract. Mental activity belongs to human beings as thinking creatures who experience both the mental and the material. Contradiction, false appearance and obscurity must also be considered. Marxism advocates the social realism of the novel. Freud considers every human being mysterious; he chooses literary works as material through which to analyse their writers. Neo-Freudians, in contrast, give priority to cultural rather than biological elements. New Criticism is based upon close and detailed attention to the work. Postmodernism, existentialism and humanism are philosophical schools. Philosophy earlier included science, history, society and politics, economics, the arts and language. As scientific and artistic fields became specialised, particularly science, philosophy moved towards mathematics, mathematical logic, and analytical methods of induction and deduction. Marx, like a divine intervention on behalf of the world's poor, made dialectics the basis of his interpretation. The contemporary 'discussion', a debate embracing both sides, already existed in the Indian philosophical practice of refutation and defence, especially in the six schools (see Mādhavācārya's *Sarvadarśanasaṃgraha*).

Francis Fukuyama, who had declared the end of history after the collapse of communist rule, subsequently retreated from the declaration. Postmodernism, too, has faltered after its initial enthusiasm. Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, Romanticism and sociological analysis survive within synthetic methods of criticism. Psychoanalysis, because of its basis in scientific inquiry, will survive like the dialectical method. Psychology may also be the foundation of a story. Its purpose should follow society's needs, and the changes in the journey of fiction should correspond to changes that have occurred and are occurring in society. At the same time, fiction is necessarily governed by the culture of that society, and its historical existence comes to light within the story. Vedic narratives express love of country and teach people to live together.

Jātaka stories aim to disseminate Buddhism alongside popular language. Among the stories of the Muslim world, Rumi's *Masnavi*, a distinguished work of Persian literature, teaches the importance of knowledge and the advancement of the state. Contemporary fiction gathers all these concerns and moves towards building an enlightened and humane society. Fukuyama announced that history created by the struggle of competing ideologies had ended, leaving only ideologies for human welfare to advance; yet he later conceded that many distinct ideologies survive within societies and among national identities.

The postmodern outlook criticises the claim that scientific knowledge is complete. It depicts truth and falsehood from different points of view; it employs self-centred humour and repeatedly dissolves distinctions between good and evil. One never knows when truth may turn into falsehood. Superficial thought is present, with neither optimism nor pessimism, but an apparent madness: things can be thought about in several ways rather than one. There is less faith in outcomes arising from causes, control and planning than in outcomes arising from coincidence. Democratic and feminist standpoints, the red flag and other ideological signs become objects of ironic laughter. Through globalisation, postmodernity brought to attention questions concerning women and communities excluded from the mainstream. It opposed ideology and universal goals but could offer no answer. Similarly, Jacques Derrida deconstructed language to demonstrate that its fragments depend upon many different foundations and that meaning cannot be understood without them.

To restore dialogue, a storyteller needs confidence grounded in reasoning and experience. Analytical positivism examines linguistic statements and concepts rather than objects. Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism arose as reactions to science and helped clarify the ambiguity of scientific thought. Phenomenology studies what is given to consciousness as given. Experience is observation of the facts of particular mental acts, a way of examining objects without bias and in their purity. In existentialism, the human being alone is the human being; one is nothing apart from what one creates and is condemned to freedom, as Sartre maintains. Hegelian dialectics emphasises judgments of the nature and existence of processes through the endless interrelation of analysis and synthesis. The deeper the essential principle, the further it stands from outer form and the nearer to reality. Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have influenced modern thought. Invisible inner and outer processes depend upon exchanges of tiny units of force and energy. Under uncertainty, position and form must be estimated rather than known exactly. The conception of a universe of more than three dimensions, and Stephen Hawking's *A Brief History of Time*, directly undermine the

existence of God, for the concept of God's death thereby comes to the fore. Just as virtual reality artificially presents reality and brings consciousness into union with it, so, without conceiving more than three dimensions, even travelling at light speed from the time of the Indus Valley civilisation would not have carried us beyond the universe today. These philosophical and scientific facts confront the short-short story as challenges. A holistic synthesis, a coordination of the whole, is required! Only then does philosophy become real rather than merely philosophical.

Poststructuralist methodology locates meaning not in words, their assigned senses or grammatical rules alone, but in the process through which meaning is made. It takes different meanings for different people and groups. There is no final relation between language and the world; no word or text has one final or uniquely determined meaning. Modernity arose from arguments about modern and postmodern reason, reality, dialogue and exchanges of thought. New Left movements then appeared in France, alongside nihilist and anarchist movements, all emerging out of distrust in the concepts and convictions of modern modes of thought. The hidden meanings of texts began to be explained in their temporal and spatial contexts, and language became a game—a language game. Postmodernism appeared as a critique of power, legitimacy and their hierarchies.

In the computer and information revolution, a maker creates software and places it on the World Wide Web, where it continues to function independently, sometimes performing tasks that were not designed for it. Other programs, such as viruses, interfere, divert it and make it destructive. Antivirus software can correct the damage; if even that fails, the computer is backed up and reformatted—a clean slate! Capitalism arose from the Industrial Revolution; now, in post-industrial society, information and communication have grown in importance relative to production, and computers assume a greater role in social life. Mobile phones, credit cards and similar objects rely on chips. Deconstruction and reconstruction indicate a reorganisation of thought and creation as consciousness assumes new forms in the post-industrial age. History has not ended, but traditional history has: the state, class, nation, party, society, family, morality and marriage are all being redefined. In the wake of rapid changes, many institutions have fragmented and lost their contexts.

A short-short story describes one aspect or event, and it need not be written on a single page. You can describe that event over three or four pages and it will still remain a short-short story. All the stories in James Joyce's *Dubliners* portray the sudden recognition of something through a particular event. Joyce's collection of fifteen stories runs to two hundred

pages and possesses all the characteristics of the Maithili short-short story. Similarly, many stories by Khalil Gibran and Anton Chekhov remain short-short stories despite being relatively long. In English and European literature, 'short story' and 'story' are sometimes used synonymously. The novel—called *upanyās* in Bengali and Maithili, and *kādambarī* in Marathi —has a much greater scope. In Maithili, a work of fifty or sixty pages may already be regarded as a novel, although this length lies at the upper boundary of the English short story, novelette and novella. But Maithili differs from English. A children's tale may continue for several nights, while an adult's story may end in minutes. It has now become apparent that, in Maithili, the short-short story occupies one page, the story three or four pages, the longer story fifteen to twenty pages, and the novel sixty to five hundred pages. I believe the permitted length of the short-short story should be extended to one to four pages.

Shardanagar

A dancer performs between two scenes of a Durga Puja play.

'Ḍhoḍhāī of Shardanagar gives ten rupees, wholeheartedly, from deep within his heart,' says the dancer Rukhsana.

'She's from Banaras, mate.'

'Oh, come on! They bring her from Muzaffarpur and then pretend she's from Banaras ...'

'But tell me, what village is this Shardanagar?'

'Don't you understand? The well-to-do people of Patti Tola built their own neighbourhood on the other side of the road and called it Lakshmipur, as if to say: we are not part of Patti Tola. Don't you know of the quarrel between Lakshmi and Saraswati? They brought that quarrel of the gods into the open. Patti Tola is the village of poor people, all of them cattle-herders. But through that divine quarrel the village was renamed Shardanagar, after Saraswati.'

'Come on. At least they are giving the dancer some money on that pretext.'

14. Maithili Drama and Modern Theatre

Abstract

The Nāṭyaśāstra states that drama originated in the festival of Indra's banner. The history of Maithili drama and theatre begins with Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrtasamāgama* and the *Aṅkiyā Nāṭ*. Modern theatre began in Calcutta around 1850 in British clubs, but outsiders were not admitted to those venues.

Keywords: Drama · Modernity · Theatre · Critical Theory · Maithili

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The history of Maithili drama and theatre begins with Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrtasamāgama* and the *Aṅkiyā Nāṭ*.

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Historical Background

Performance was the dominant element in *Aṅkiyā Nāṭ* as well. The *Kīrtaniyā* tradition was in one sense musical, yet acting was predominant there too. An *Aṅkiyā* performance began with the playing of the *mṛdaṅga*.

Classical Foundations

The bronze figurine recovered from the civilisation of Mohenjo-daro suggests a dancing posture resembling the *ṭhāṭ* position of present-day Kathak: the right arm forming an angle of forty-five degrees, the left hand resting at the left hip, and the left leg slightly bent. The Śāṅkhāyana Brāhmaṇa of the Ṛgveda describes the combined use of song, instrumental music and dance; the Aitareya Brāhmaṇa counts all three among the divine crafts. In Ṛgveda 10.76.6, the golden radiance of Uṣas reminds the poet of an adorned seer. The Ṛgveda also mentions folk dancing (*prāñco agāma nṛtaye*). A collective dance by female servants—three to six of them—is described in the Soma sacrifice known as the *Mahāvrata*. Śāṅkhāyana 1.11.5 describes four to eight married women being given *surā* at a wedding and encouraged to dance four times. Vedic literature refers to the bride's singing as part of the wedding rites. During the *sīmantonnayana* ceremony, the husband requests a vīṇā player to perform a song with instrumental accompaniment in praise of Soma. The Atharvaveda associates the dance of the deity named Vasā with Ṛc, Sāman and *gāthā*, and describes Gandharvas taking part in this Soma-drinking dance. Atharvaveda 12.1.41 describes the collective sound of singing, instrumental music and dancing. Alongside Sāman music, secular narrative-song traditions called *gāthā* and *nārāśaṃsī* were also current in

the Vedic period. Ṛgveda 1.115.2 compares the rising sun at dawn to a young man following a beautiful woman. Ṛgveda 1.124.11 describes the red glow of daybreak, the retreating darkness and the fire in the hearth, with the image of a young village woman letting a red cow out to graze. Atharvaveda 4.15.6 refers to a collective cry. Yajurveda 40.16 describes the solar disc as a golden vessel covering the sun. Yajurveda 17.38–41 depicts the divine army going into battle accompanied by instruments, while 17.49 evokes the rustling sound of armour. Ṛgveda 1.164.2 and Yāska 4.27 describe the year and the wheel. Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad 2.2.3 describes the source of Soma juice; 2.2.4 refers to seven sages on its banks as the eyes, ears and other organs. In Atharvaveda 10.2.31 the body is called Ayodhyā, and in Bhagavad Gītā 5.13 it is called a city.

Drama in the Yajurveda: The Yajurveda contains certain technical terms, such as *sūta*, *śailūṣa* and *citrakāriṇī*, suggesting that the idea of a theatre pavilion may already have existed.

Thinkers of both East and West have offered their views on the social purpose of art, literature and music and the ethical standards by which they ought to be judged. Plato argues that art cannot be good, because it is false and unreal. Yet art, music and literature may also exist for one's own delight: reading, hearing, seeing and experiencing them can give pleasure and peace of mind, and at other times can disturb and agitate us. Aristotle, by contrast, holds that artists possess knowledge and help us understand the world. Once words are uttered and works of art made, the object of understanding comes into existence. Its propriety is established through words and sounds, form, *rasa*, melody, metre and ornamentation.

Drama, previously performed at temple festivals and in royal palaces, then acquired an independent existence; its uses and applications also extended to the teaching of other subjects.

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra

Dramatic Presentation and Acting

Kālidāsa's *Abhijñānaśākuntalam* is essential reading for a stage director. Its stage directions include *ratha-vegaṃ nirūpya*, *sūta paśyainaṃ vyāpādyamānaṃ*, *iti śarasaṃdhānam nāṭayati*, *vṛkṣa-secanaṃ rūpayati*, *kalaśam avarjayati*, *mukham asyāḥ samunnamayitum icchati*, *Śakuntalā pariharati nāṭyena* and *nāṭyena prasādhayataḥ*. These things are accomplished not literally but by acting. In *nāṭyena prasādhayataḥ*, Anasūyā and Priyaṃvadā mime adorning their friend Śakuntalā through gestures, either because the necessary objects are unavailable or because there is insufficient time. Likewise, *vṛkṣa-secanaṃ rūpayati* indicates miming the watering of a tree; *kalaśam avarjayati* directs the actor to imagine emptying a vessel; *ratha-vegaṃ nirūpya* signifies acting out a

swift chariot journey; *iti śarasaṃdhānam nāṭayati* signifies the action of fitting an arrow to a bow; *sūta paśyainaṃ vyāpādyamānaṃ* instructs the charioteer to observe the deer being brought down; *mukham asyāḥ samunnamayitum icchati* expresses Duṣyanta's wish to raise Śakuntalā's face; and *Śakuntalā pariharati nāṭyena* directs Śakuntalā to mime resisting Duṣyanta's attempt. A study of Indian and Western dramatic theory reveals striking similarities in human thought despite geographical distances. Indian dramaturgy is grounded chiefly in Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* and Dhanañjaya's *Daśarūpaka*; the authoritative Western text is Aristotle's *Poetics*. Bharata calls drama *kṛtānusāra* and *bhāvānukāra*, while Dhanañjaya defines it as an imitation of a condition or state. In Indian literary theory, imitation is the actor's activity, not the poet's. In the Western account it is the poet's activity, while the actor receives no corresponding discussion. Aristotle places particular emphasis on plot. Tragedy consists of plot together with characterisation, diction, thought, spectacle and song. Bharata calls the plot concerning the hero *ādhikārika*, and the supporting plot *prāsaṅgika*; not every drama, however, requires a subsidiary plot. Western stagecraft is realistic, while Indian stagecraft is symbolic. Kālidāsa, for example, writes in *Abhijñānaśākuntalam*: *iti śarasaṃdhānaṃ nāṭayati*—the actor mimes setting the arrow. According to Bharata, dramatic effect gives rise to *rasa*. What is drama for? It is for enacting *rasa* and also for producing it. How does *rasa* emerge? Through its causes (*vibhāva*), its manifestations (*anubhāva*) and accompanying, transitory emotional states (*vyabhicāribhāva*). The durable emotion (*sthāyibhāva*) becomes concentrated and ripens into *rasa*, whose flavour we can savour.

After the Buddhist *Caryāgīti* came King Nānyadeva's *Sarasvatīhṛdayālaṅkāra*; tradition then places Vidyāpati and the musician Jayat in the court of Śiva Siṃha. In Vidyāpati's *Puruṣaparīkṣā* stories, a man's love of art and music is regarded as important as his *puruṣārtha*. Śubhaṅkara Ṭhākura's *Śrīhastamuktāvalī* is also regarded as a work of Mithila, though some scholars, on the evidence of surviving manuscripts, consider it to have been composed in Assam. The work offers an extensive account of hand movements associated with acting. The *Ā'īn-i Akbarī* mentions Vidyāpati's *nacārī* songs.

At the Videha Theatre Festival in 2012, *Ulkāmukha*, written by Gajendra Thakur and directed by Bechan Thakur, was staged with a conception of theatre based on Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra*. It was the first such attempt in Maithili. The production used an all-women cast, with female performers playing the male roles as well. The stage design, based on the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, was drawn by Mrs S. S. Janaki. A comparable attempt had been made in Sanskrit theatre in Chennai.

A Parallel World of Maithili Drama

Ramkhelawan Mandar was from Katghara village, Shivajinagar block, Samastipur district. Bindeshwar Mandal also worked with him. People still remember the opening Maithili chorus and the line: "Mother, oh mother, buy me a gun, for I shall become a soldier, mother." The troupe performed verse-dramas such as *Reshma-Chūhaṛ*, *Śīt-Basant*, *Ālhā-Ūdal* and *Naṭuā Dayāl*.

The Maithili *Bidesiyā—Piā Desāntar* troupe came from Saharsa, Supaul and Purnia.

A dramatic piece called *Hāsan-Husan* was also performed.

The Ramraksha Chaudhary Dramatic Arts Council, of Gayghat village, Kariyan panchayat, post office Vaidyanathpur, Samastipur district, took its production of *Vidyāpati* as far as Gorakhpur. Other plays performed by this troupe were *Lauṅgiyā Mercāi*, *Vidyāpati*, *Cīnīk Laḍḍū* and *Basāt*.

Efforts should also be made to document and honour this parallel world of Maithili drama.

Theatre and Stage Organisations

Bhaṅgimā, Patna; Cetanā Samiti, Patna; Jamghaṭ, Madhubani; Mithila Vikas Parishad, Kolkata; Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, Kolkata; Mithila Kala Kendra, Kolkata; Maithili Rangmanch, Kolkata; Kurmi-Kshatriya Scholarship Fund, Kolkata; All India Maithil Sangh, Kolkata; Karna Goshthi: Jayant Lokmanch, Kolkata; Mithila Seva Sansthan, Kolkata; Mithi Yatrik, Kolkata; Vaidehi Kala Manch, Kolkata; Kokil Manch, Kolkata; Mithila Kalyan Parishad, Rishra, Kolkata (primarily directed by Mr Dayanath Jha since 1982; at present Mr Ranjit Kumar Jha directs it, and on 8 January 2012 he directed the staging of *Upanayanak Bhoj*, written by Tantranath Jha); Jhankar, Kolkata; Mithila Seva Samiti, Belur, Kolkata; Uday Path, Kolkata; Mithila Natya Parishad (MINAP), Janakpur; Ramanand Yuva Club, Janakpurdham; Yuva Natya Kala Parishad (YUNAP), Parwaha, Dhanusha; Akriti (Upendra Bhagat Nagvanshi), Janakpur; Rang Vatika, Nepal; Chabutara; Shiromani Maithili Yuva Club, Ganguli; Bhairab; Maithili Sanskritik Yuva Club, Bauharba; Shri Saraswati Sanskritik Natya Kala Parishad, Tilathi village (Saptari, Nepal); Arunoday Natya Manch, Rajbiraj; Saraswati Natya Kala Parishad, Menhath, Madhubani; Maithili Lok Rang (Mailorang), Delhi; Mithilangan, Delhi. At Pajuaridih hamlet in Madhubani, the Shri Krishna Natya Samiti has continued staging Maithili plays under the direction of Shri Krishnachandra Jha Rasik, Shivnath Jha and Ganga Jha. Also: Sanskritik Manch, Lohianagar, Patna; Chitragupta Sanskritik Kendra, Janakpur; Gardanibagh Kala Samiti, Patna; Mithilakshar, Jamshedpur; Maithili Kala Manch, Bokaro; Ugna Vidyapati Parishad, Begusarai; Mithila Sanskritik

Parishad, Bokaro Steel City; Bhanu Kala Kendra, Biratnagar; Aangan, Patna; Navtarang, Begusarai; Bharatiya Rangmanch, Darbhanga; Bhadrakali Natya Parishad, Koilakh; Mithila Anubhuti, Darbhanga; the theatre festival of the Videha International e-Journal; and Nav Jyoti Dramatic Club, Laukahi (which staged *Brahmasthan* and *Ugna* in 1992 with Shambhu Shankar and others).

Directors: Kalikant Jha "Booch"; Kamdev Pathak; Shri Kamal Narayan Karna (*Cīnīk Laḍḍū*, by Ishanath Jha; *Cāripahar*, originally in Bengali by Kiran Maitra and translated into Maithili by Nirasan Labh); Shri Shrikant Mandal (*Chandragupta*, originally in Bengali by D. L. Roy, translated into Maithili by Babu Saheb Chaudhary; *Pāthey*, by Gunanath Jha; *Nāyakak Nām Jīvan*, by Nachiketa); Shri Vishnu Chatterjee and Shri Shrikant Mandal (*Niṣkalaṅk*, by Janardan Jha); Prabir Mukhopadhyay; Veena Roy; Mohan Chaudhary; Babu Ram Singh; Gopal Das; Kunal; Ravi Dev; Dayanath Jha; Trilochan Jha; Shambhunath Mishra; Kashi Jha; Ashok Jha; Ganga Jha; Ganesh Prasad Sinha; Navin Chandra Mishra; Janardan Roy; Shri Krishnachandra Jha Rasik; Shivnath Jha; Rabindranath Thakur; Akhileshwar; Sachchidanand; Ramesh Rajhans; Modnath Jha; Vibhuti Anand; Javed Akhtar Khan; Kaushal Kishore Das; Prashant Kant; Arvind Ranjan Das; Manoj Manu; Rohini Raman Jha; Bhavnath Jha; Umakant Jha; Lallan Prasad Thakur; Raghunath Jha Kiran; Mahendra Malangia; Kumar Shailendra; Vineet Jha; Kishore Kumar Jha; Kumar Gagan; Vinod Kumar Jha; K. Ajay; Chhatranand Singh Jha; Neelam Chaudhary; Kajal; Manoj Kumar Pathak; Ashnarayan Mishra; Shri Shrinarayan Jha; Pramila Jha; Tanuja Shankar; Keshav Nandan; Brahmanand Jha; Sanjeev Tamanna; Kislay Krishna; Prakash Jha; Munnaji; Sanjay Kumar Chaudhary; Kamal Mohan Chunnu; Anshuman Satyaketu; Shyam Bhaskar; Prem Kumar; Sangam Kumar Thakur; L. R. M. Rajan; Bhaskaranand Jha; Ashutosh Kumar Mishra; Anand Kumar Jha; Manoj Manuj; Sanjeev Mishra; Swati Singh; Swarnim; Ashutosh Yadav Abhigya; Ashok Ashk; Dilip Vats; Tarun Prabhat; Madhav Anand; Narendra Mishra; Bharat Bhushan Jha; Kishore Keshav; Bechan Thakur; Upendra Bhagat Nagvanshi; Anil Chandra Jha; Anshuman Satyaketu; Anand Kumar Jha; Hemnarayan Sahu; Ramkrishna Mandal Chhotu; Dhirendra Kumar; Utpal Jha; Abhishek K. Narayan; Chandrika Prasad.

Plays and Playwrights

Dhūrtasamāgama was composed by Jyotirishwar Thakur in the thirteenth century. He incorporated Maithili songs into this work, which belongs to the category of farce. Most early Maithili plays and dramatic pieces were based on the lives of Krishna and his descendants or on stories of abduction and *svayaṃvara*. In *Dhūrtasamāgama*, however, the central characters are a mendicant and his disciple. Every character is a rogue outdoing the others in roguery; hence the title, *The Assembly of Rogues*, is

entirely apt. A farce is also called a kind of musical performance, making the inclusion of Maithili songs particularly appropriate. The principal characters are the Sūtradhāra, the actress, Snātaka, Viśvanagara, Mṛtāṅgāra, Suratpriyā, Anaṅgasenā, Asajjātimiśra, Bandhuvañcaka, Mūlanāśaka and a citizen. The Sūtradhāra praises the Karnata sovereign Narasiṃhadeva, followed by praise of Jyotirishwar. The play contains a kind of absurdity that is thoroughly modern, and its flexibility makes it a work of folk theatre. Viśvanagara is a celibate because he has no woman. When he and his disciple Snātaka go to Mṛtāṅgāra Thakur's house to beg, the excuse of ritual impurity is offered. Viśvanagara and Snātaka next visit Suratpriyā's house for alms. Then the teacher and disciple quarrel violently over a courtesan named Anaṅgasenā. They take her to Asajjātimiśra, who proves to be a libertine himself. ... Miśra proves to be a libertine. ... He regards the management of gambling and sexual intercourse as the two essentials of worldly life. Asajjātimiśra asks who is the plaintiff and who the defendant. Snātaka replies: "I am the plaintiff because I shall state the accusation, and the ascetic is the defendant because he must pay the fee." Viśvanagara offers Snātaka's bundle of cannabis as payment. The jester whispers praise of Anaṅgasenā's sexual charms into Asajjātimiśra's ear. Placing Anaṅgasenā between the disputants, Miśra delivers judgment in his own favour. Meanwhile the jester tells Anaṅgasenā privately: "The ascetic is poor, Snātaka is a vagabond, and this Miśra is a fool; therefore stay with me." Looking around at all four, Anaṅgasenā exclaims that this has indeed become an assembly of rogues.

Viśvanagara and Snātaka set off once again towards Suratpriyā's house. Meanwhile a barber named Mūlanāśaka asks Anaṅgasenā for a year's payment for his services. She sends him to Asajjātimiśra. Mūlanāśaka assumes Miśra to be Anaṅgasenā's bridegroom. Taking the cannabis as his fee, he forces Miśra down, binds him and massages him so vigorously that he faints. Thinking him dead, the barber flees. The jester arrives, unties him and asks: "I have saved your life; if there is anything else you would like me to do, tell me." Asajjātimiśra answers: "Through deceit I devoured the entire country, through roguery I obtained this beloved woman, and I have also found an obedient disciple like you. Nothing dearer remains for me. Nevertheless, I wish for happiness and peace everywhere."

Jeevan Jha

The plays written by Jeevan Jha include *Sundar Saṃyog* (1904), *Maithili Saṭṭak* (1906), *Narmadā Sāgar Saṭṭak* (1906) and *Sāmavatī Punarjanma* (1908).

All four had been performed repeatedly at the Samaveda School in Kashi before 1920, and *Sundar Saṃyog* was also published there.

Some Other Productions of *Sundar Saṃyog*

1974: On the premises of Lakshminarayan High School at Mali Mortar, beside the Hasanpur sugar mill, during Durga Puja. Director: Shri Kalikant Jha "Booch"; chief guest: Shri Fazlur Rahman Hasmi. The organisers were Devnandan Pathak, Chief Engineer, and Keshnandan Pathak ("Auditor Tika Babu"); the inauguration was by village head Udit Rai.

1976: Kariyan, Samastipur. Director: Kamdev Pathak.

1981: Pandit Tola, Tabhka, near Dalsinghsarai. Conveners: Dr Umendra Jha "Vimal", former Pro-Vice-Chancellor of K. S. Sanskrit University, and Mahamahopadhyaya Chitradhar Mishra, the officiant at the Shiva temple inside Darbhanga Fort, whose pupils included Mahamahopadhyaya Umesh Mishra and Mahamahopadhyaya Ganganath Jha.

1983: Mau Bajitpur, near Vidyapatinagar.

These plays, rich in features of the Sanskrit tradition and Parsi theatre, were performed in various other places as well.

Ishanath Jha

Ugnā: These plays are performed on Mahashivaratri at Gaurishankar Sthan, Jamthuri. Vidyapati is a devotee of Shiva. Wishing to hear his devotional *nacārī* songs, Shiva comes to Vidyapati's home as a servant named Ugna. On one occasion Vidyapati is travelling with Ugna and becomes thirsty. Ugna draws water from the Ganga held in his matted hair and gives it to Vidyapati. But Vidyapati recognises the taste of Ganga water and, seeing Ugna's wet hair, understands everything. Ugna appears in his true form. He warns Vidyapati not to tell anyone or he will disappear. Parvati then contrives a situation: Vidyapati's wife sends Ugna to fetch *bel* leaves, and when he is late she raises a broom against him. Vidyapati discloses the secret, and Ugna vanishes. *Cīnīk Laḍḍū*: Sudhakant and Premkant's father dies, and their maternal uncle Dharmanand looks after them as a trustee. Once they are capable of managing their affairs, he hands responsibility to Sudhakant and returns home. Sudhakant's clerk Batua Das, assisted by Premkant's wife Chandika and a maid named Chhulahi, arranges a division of the property; Sudhakant gives even his own share to Premkant. Sudhakant, his wife Sushila and their son Sukumar are driven out. Tuberculosis kills Sudhakant. The company of Batua Das reduces Premkant to poverty as well. The childless uncle Dharmanand bequeaths his property to Sukumar. Premkant and Batua Das try to kill Sukumar by giving him sugar *laḍḍūs* mixed with poison as a gift, but Batua Das himself dies from them and the plot is exposed.

Udaynarayan Singh "Nachiketa"

Nāyakak Nām Jīvan: Naval is a thinker of new ideas. Shaktirai is rich and corrupt; he accuses his associate Vinay of theft and has Vinay's daughter abducted and raped. Vinay takes his own life. Naval and his friends Prakash and Deepak uncover the whole conspiracy. Naval's beloved dies by suicide following the rape, and Naval becomes mentally deranged. *Ek Chhal Rājā*: A king named Abhiman Kumar Dev has squandered his days on drink and courtesans. He has only one daughter, Mohini, whose marriage cannot take place for want of money. The drama proceeds through the characters of the clerk Viranchi, the servant Chatur Lal and the king's religiously observant wife. Mohini and her teacher Shubhankar fall in love. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*: A postmodern drama whose absurdity recalls Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrtasamāgama*. The dead arrive at the gates of heaven or hell and tell their stories. It eventually emerges that Chitragupta and Dharmaraj are impostors and the gate is locked: no entry.

Govind Jha

Basāt: Krishnakant refuses to marry Pushpa, the young woman chosen by his father. He wishes to marry an educated woman and loves Lily. His father leaves home. Pushpa, too, leaves her home and devotes herself to women's awakening. Krishnakant fails to locate his father, abandons Lily, and intends to die beneath a train. People from an ashram save him, and there he meets his father and Pushpa. Lily also arrives, in a state of mental distress.

Gunanath Jha

He edited and managed the Maithili theatre periodical *Lok Manch* and pioneered modern drama in Maithili. His plays *Kaniyā-Putarā*, *Pāthey*, *Madhuyāminī*, *Sātam Caritra*, *Śeṣa Nañi*, *Ājuk Lok* and *Jai Maithili* have been staged repeatedly. *Bāṅglā Ekāṅkī Nāṭya-Saṅgraha* is a collection of twenty-four plays by twenty-four Bengali playwrights, compiled and edited by Ajit Kumar Ghosh and translated from Bengali into Maithili by Shri Gunanath Jha.

Kaniyā-Putarā: This is Gunanath Jha's first full-length play, suitable for a revolving stage that accommodates many scenes. The narrative concerns the *kāṭar* marriage custom. Its consequences lead the principal male and female characters into psychological disturbance, and the play presents an accurate portrayal and analysis of their mental states.

Madhuyāminī: A one-act play with two characters: the man supports the joint-family system, while the woman opposes it. A harmonious victory goes to the advocate of the joint family. It was published in the Maithili theatre journal *Lok Manch*.

Pāthey: Written in the form of a one-act play, it nonetheless possesses all the characteristics of a full-length work. Distressed by Mithila's decline, the protagonist decides to make his village the centre of his work. His relatives oppose him, but eventually his wife joins him. The language is sweet and flowing.

Lāl-Bujhakkar: A one-act play. People of the lower and lower-middle classes, devastated by floods and droughts, are compelled to migrate for a livelihood both before and after Independence. Orphaned Lal-Bujhakkar leaves his wife at her parental home and his childless paternal uncle and aunt behind, and migrates to a city.

Sātam Caritra: A one-act play about the absence of women performers on the Maithili stage. Rehearsal ends while everyone is still waiting for the actress who is to play the seventh character. It appeared in the Maithili theatre journal *Lok Manch*.

Śeṣa Nañi: A full-length modern social drama. After the parents' deaths, the elder brother behaves as a father towards the younger one. The younger brother finds employment but, caught in changing social circumstances, acts in unimaginable ways and mistreats his elder brother. The elder brother nevertheless takes a courageous step to save his dying wife's life.

Ājuk Lok: A full-length play concerning lower-middle-class unemployment and the burden of marriage responsibilities.

Jai Maithili: A full-length play whose subject is Mithila's linguistic and cultural problems.

Mahākavi Vidyāpati: A new interpretation of Vidyapati.

Mahendra Malangia

Ek Kamal Norme: Mala urges her husband Rajesh to take a second wife in order to have children, but he refuses. Her mother-in-law conspires with an astrologer to take obscene photographs of the unconscious Mala with another man and shows them to Rajesh. Rajesh expels Mala from home and marries the astrologer's daughter. Mala takes her own life. *Juāyal Kankanī*: Jibu blames his aunt for the suicides of his parents, but later discovers that Baiju sexually violated his sister. Revenge and remorse follow. *Okarā Āṅganak Bārahamāsā*: An account of the lives of labourers through the twelve months of the year. *Chutahar / Chutahar Ghail / Chutahā Ghail.*

Chutahā Ghail is the title of a recent play by Mahendra Malangia. He has written a ten-page preface to this short play.

Let us first examine the preface. He is aggrieved that Ramanand Jha "Raman" suggested that *Chutahar Ghail* should simply be called *Chutahar*. He therefore raises three points. First:

"What you write in books,

I have seen with my own eyes."

Second, a lament by Yatri Ji:

"I remain to one side, like a *ghail chutahar*;

Alas, how deeply unfortunate I am!"

He adds: what use to the widow in that poem or to Kabutari Devi in this play are Shiva's *Māheśvara Sūtras* and Pāṇini's ten verbal tenses and moods (Pāṇini having set out twelve *lakāras* for Vedic Sanskrit and ten for classical Sanskrit—well, let that pass)?

Third, he likens his position to that of Copernicus: why should what people say matter when ordinary villagers do indeed say *Chutahar Ghail*?

But all three arguments turn against Malangia himself. "Seen with one's own eyes" and actual popular usage show that the word spoken is simply *chutahar*. Can a *chutahar* be placed upon a *ghailchī*? Water is poured over the vegetable patch from a *loiṭ*; according to Malangia's logic, it should then be called a "*loiṭ ghail*." *Ghail*, *surāhī*, *kohā*, *taulā*, *chutahar*, *loiṭ*, *khāpaṛi*, *kuṛnī*, *kurwāṛ*, *kosiyā*, *sarbā* and *sobarnā* are all distinct objects with different names. Accepting the suggestion of Phoolchandra Mishra "Raman" (who perhaps proposed *Chutahā Ghail* jokingly—and if not, it is a new word in a new language), Malangia changed *Chutahar Ghail* to *Chutahā Ghail*. This shows that he had realised his mistake; but rather than appear diminished by accepting Ramanand Jha "Raman"'s observation, he planted his own flag. Later Ramanand Jha "Raman" urged Chetana Samiti to publish the book, and because the Samiti would give him only twenty-five copies, Malangia published it through his own organisation. What concern are all these matters of the reader's? Now consider Yatri Ji. He also had Hindi readers in mind and sometimes did not remember which poem was in Hindi, which in Maithili and which in both. Thus he wrote *chutahar ghail*. We may also see the explanation in his desire to make the rhyme work. And now Copernicus: even if Yatri Ji or Malangia wrote *ghail chutahar*, *chutahar ghail* or *chutahā ghail*, would native speakers of Maithili begin calling a *chutahar* by any of those composite names? Thus Copernicus, too, stands against Malangia.

Malangia has not used the story of Copernicus accurately. He seems to be confusing Copernicus with Galileo. The Copernican theory had the support of the pope, and Copernicus dedicated a forty-page manuscript concerning his heliocentric theory to Pope Paul III. In any event, Malangia's unfamiliarity with science, and his habit of linking scientific

theory with legend, will not surprise the reader after seeing the ignorance of genuine folktales displayed in this very preface.

Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves: Everyone knows this is a medieval Arab folktale associated with *The Arabian Nights* (the *Thousand and One Nights*). There is debate as to whether it was inserted into that collection at a later stage, but no dispute, the author argues, over its status as a medieval Arab folktale. The many things Malangia says about Balban's atrocities and the like from a communal perspective reveal only a superficial attachment to folklore. The shallow understanding of *Mithila Tattva Vimarśa* or Ramanath Jha's genealogical registers has long since been corrected, and these matters are recorded in written form in our *pañjī* books. Gonu Jha lived three hundred years before Vidyapati, yet Malangia proceeds on the basis of fifty-year-old gossip. He knows that Gonu has been called *Dhūrtācārya* ("preceptor of rogues"), but he does not know that Gonu was also called *Mahāmahopādhyāya*. Muslims were not even living in Mithila in Gonu Jha's time, so where could a "tax-collector's beard" of that kind come from? Transform the popular word *chutahar* into *chutahā ghail*, turn the familiar beard of a tax collector into the beard of a *tahsildar*, declare a Muslim to be an oppressor on communal grounds, and write such a preface that Ramanand Jha "Raman" and others will be afraid to review it. The Satnami rebellion, beginning with a conflict between a foot soldier and a Satnami (a progressive sect established by Dalit and backward communities), opposed Aurangzeb's policies and included the burning of a mosque. But Gonu Jha's tax collector was not a Muslim; the folktale contains no such claim. If a communally minded storyteller forces an ideology into the story and falsifies it in writing, how is Maithili folklore responsible? This is what happens when folktales are not collected through fieldwork.

Mahendra Narayan Ram writes that folktales recognise no caste distinctions. How, however, would Malangia accept that? A *bhagatā* also unfailingly appears in his story. The real reason this character becomes integral to Malangia's play is the playwright's inherited assumption of caste superiority. The play consists of seventeen scenes, each approximately two and a half pages long. Through the fifteenth scene he follows his old method of making upper-caste audiences laugh at the supposed speech of lower castes (a language of his own invention), and producing counterfeit comedy through the *bhagatā*'s corrupt Hindi. He attempts to make the story purposeful only from the sixteenth scene onward; by then he has lost his hold on it. At a time when even Sanskrit productions no longer necessarily use Prakrit or another language in this manner, Malangia's invocation of Bharata out of context reveals his unfamiliarity with Sanskrit and suggests that his acquaintance with the *Nāṭyaśāstra* comes through secondary works written in Hindi.

Does Malangia mean that a play which is good to read cannot be stageworthy, or that one written for performance cannot make good reading? That is what his Sanskrit quotation seems to imply. If a drama does not stir its reader, how is a director to decide to stage it? And what exactly are its theatrical qualities? Seventeen scenes of two and a half pages each, casteist language insulting the so-called lower classes, the *bhagatā*'s Hindi catchphrase "*bujhtā hai ki nahī?*" ("Do you understand or not?"), and the "slapstick humour" produced by their combination? Anyone who opposes this and proposes a parallel Maithili theatre is then dismissed as someone who insists upon the readable aspect of drama, while the traditionalist casteist is presented as the defender of its theatrical aspect. Would Malangia's caste-based sentence patterns be acceptable in a twenty-first-century Sanskrit, Hindi or other modern Indian-language drama (apart from Maithili)? If not, why are irrelevant statements from eighteen-hundred-year-old Sanskrit drama repeatedly used as a shield for this vocabulary by a playwright who has not read Bharata's original Sanskrit *Nāṭyaśāstra*? Does carrying a basket on one's head and a child under one's arm necessarily identify someone as lower-class? In *Okarā Āṅganak Bārahamāsā* he calls this class *rāṛ*. Decades later, he has at least improved enough to call them the "lower class"; that change is welcome, but very little for so long a period. How did the *bābājī* enter the story, how did cannabis enter it, and what connection does that have with the trees in the orchard? How could Malangia have inserted his caste-based sentence structures and corrupt-Hindi constructions without introducing the contrived ideas of the *bhagatā* and the lower class? He tries very cleverly to conceal this fact and therefore cannot move beyond mediocrity. He wants to make the dramatic story purposeful but cannot achieve the requisite artistic power.

Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary

Bhaphāit Cāhak Jingī: Mahesh is unemployed and opens a tea shop; he is also a poet. Chandrama, wife of the engineer Umanath, sees at the shop that Mahesh has been called away for a poetry recital and begins selling the tea herself. Umanath becomes angry. Mahesh's friend Sarita, who is married to an IAS officer, arrives. *Leṭāit Āčar*: Dinanath's only daughter Mamta is abandoned by her husband because of the *kāṭar* custom. But when Dinanath tries to take dowry at the marriage of his son Modnath, the son stops him.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal

Mithilāk Beṭī, Act One: Employees strike against rising prices. Among the causes of inflation are the preference for salaried jobs and the decline of agriculture. Landed wealth diminishes, and the complications of gifts and dowry increase. There is ostentation at weddings, misuse of money, and

the artist's contempt for material wealth. A college girl learning song and dance runs away with a cornet player. Pickpocketing flourishes amid disorder. Government officers are forbidden to speak. Kidnapping increases, with varied motives involving not merely money but people's very lives. The moral decline of government officials, an incident involving a spoon, and the growth of insecurity as the administrative apparatus weakens all appear. Caste and sectarianism contribute to social disintegration until even honour and reputation are endangered. Influenced by cinema, sports and recreation, a new generation is abandoning lineage, family custom and conduct and blindly imitating outside fashions. The values of a collapsing feudal order leave their mark. Wells and ponds become places where women quarrel. Sita symbolises the strength of the women of Mithila. Dowry destroys caste distinctions; riches destroy codes of conduct, while litigation and mutual conflict draw society into their grip. Young men lack self-confidence; women show immense patience; the condition of the child-widow reveals society's impact upon the individual. Even the worth of an educated and capable girl is nullified before dowry. Women's importance has in any case been diminished by the male-dominated system, and ornaments and jewellery can also be harmful. A new enthusiasm is needed among the women of the younger generation, along with the ability to learn new kinds of work. Act Two: A feudal addiction—*bhāṅg*—also affects the young. People shirk labour, refuse hard work and rely on fate. Money breaks families apart. Conflict between father and son; marriage of boys and girls through coercion or persuasion; fraud in land transactions, including forced dealings and duplicate registrations. Earnings from bribery confer prestige; even parents wish their sons to take bribes. Opposition to salaried employment; various kinds of oppression of women in a patriarchal system; education creates further problems as well. Act Three: The harmful effects of multinational corporations on agriculture and the shortage of domestic production. Society splits into supporters and opponents of dowry, into defenders of tradition and a newly awakened opposition to it. Society is fragmented into factions. A new human being, new technology, new thinking and new work emerge. Multinational influence has harmful consequences for the family, society, art and culture. Changing the system will change society. Act Four: Wealth changes attitudes and may inaugurate a new society. Ramvilas, a craftsman, values the human being and thereby challenges dowry. People from Mithila have long travelled to Bengal, Assam, Nepal and Dhaka to harvest paddy and jute. Contradictions within education must be overcome. Act Five: An ideal marriage, and the awakening of a new consciousness capable of changing the social system.

Compromise: The collapse of agriculture and peasant life under feudal society; the reorganisation of agriculture as capital under a new capitalist order; the deteriorating condition of the village as intellectuals and labourers migrate; and a philosophy of reconciliation and coordination.

Jhameliyā Biāh: Various external influences affecting the marriage rites of Mithila; the disputes and complications born of these influences; and a detailed examination of the controversies produced by marriage procedures.

Birāṅganā: Rural life becoming market-oriented; capitalist exploitation made possible by cheap labour; the plunder of labour forcing villagers into lives worse than those of animals; and people ready to perform the most degrading acts for money.

Tāmak Tamghail: The fragmentation of families, customary practices and family relationships as feudal society collapses, together with the disintegration of the family's economic base.

Satmāe: Relationships are not in themselves defective; the defects lie in human behaviour and thought. The play examines these matters and presents an ideal version of the stepmother.

Kalyāṇī: A portrayal of women's awakening and vigilance against injustices committed in broad daylight, drawing attention to fundamental problems and to the enormous price that may have to be paid to resolve them.

Samjhautā: An account of the basic problems arising from the breakdown of agrarian culture as agriculture is transformed into capital; it explains the importance and necessity of considered compromise as a way of addressing those problems.

Anand Kumar Jha

Ṭāṭak Mol: A play based on the *kāṭar* custom. Garibnath and Sumitra, longing for a son, have five daughters. Much of their farmland is sold to pay for the eldest daughter's wedding. Only twelve *kaṭṭhās* of land remain for the second daughter's marriage. Their daughter Prabha attends college and loves her sister's brother-in-law Prabhakar; a young, much-desired brother tends buffaloes.

Kalah: Akash is unemployed. His stepmother Sumitra torments the elder son for the sake of her own son Rajiv. An innocent child is born …

Badalait Samāj: Ghooran Ji, who has blood cancer, arranges the marriage of his ailing son, though he himself does not know that his son Avadhesh is suffering from blood cancer. Avadhesh, the son of village head Bhajendra, dies. At the end the play imagines the remarriage of the widow Shobha to a virtuous young man named Vijendra.

Dhadhāit Navkī Kaniyāk Lahās: Shikha attempts suicide over a few pieces of jewellery.

Haṭhāt Parivartan: A patriotic play.

Gajendra Thakur

Ulkāmukha: Its first production was directed by Bechan Thakur. This work of magical realism exposes a conspiracy in history, with a stage conception drawn from Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Its characters include Ācārya Vyāghra, Ācārya Siṃha, Ācārya Śarabha, the disciples Sāhī, Khikhir, Naṛhiyā and Bijjī. The characters change between the first and fourth *kallolas*; in a second form beginning with the fifth *kallola*, four women characters are added: Rudramati (Madhav's mother), Sohago (Gangadhar's mother), Ananda (Gangadhar's sister), and Medha (the daughter of the general Harikar). The play concerns the love of Gangesh and Vallabha. Yet after the first two acts, the third and fourth become examples of magical realism. Udayan, Dina, Bhadri, Ācārya Vyāghra, Ācārya Siṃha, Ācārya Śarabha, and the disciples Sāhī, Khikhir, Naṛhiyā and Bijjī appear before us, and the enactment of a conspiracy in history begins. But at the end of the fourth *kallola*, the *bhagatā* reveals a secret to his disciple—a secret that will be remembered even after it has been forgotten. ... Become *Ulkāmukha* ... From the fifth *kallola*, reality replaces suggestion and truth replaces imagination. From the first through the fourth *kallola*, cubes marked with chessboard designs will stand on stage; from the fifth, these signs of the past and imagination will be replaced by spheres symbolising reality. Many commentaries on Gangesh's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* are available, and he is known as Gangesh, the author of *Tattvacintāmaṇi*; yet his poetry has become *Ulkāmukha*!

Saṅkarṣaṇ: A character who is considered clever, devious and cunning in his village begins to lose his intelligence on the journey to Delhi and, once there, regards himself as a fool. A folktale about a dog from Haryana, India, is also woven into the work.

Bhaʹ Jāeb Chū: A children's crossroads or street play, part of a campaign to popularise environmental awareness and science through street theatre.

Bechan Thakur

Beṭīk Apamān and *Chhīnardevi*: Both plays, dealing with female foeticide, women's rights and superstition, take Maithili theatre in a new direction.

Adhikār: The story of the real-life Manzoor, who exposed irregularities in the Indira Awas housing scheme through the Right to Information Act and travelled by rickshaw from Jhanjharpur to Delhi.

Viśvāsghāt: Large compensation payments are made for land acquired for a national highway, and family relationships are sacrificed in attempts to seize the money.

15. Foundations of Maithili Theatre Criticism: Text, Performability and Comparative Method

Abstract

This chapter establishes a critical method that treats drama not merely as a written text but as a composite art of acting, audience, stage structure, folk memory and performance practice. Its application to a collection of plays offers a working model for the comparative use of Indian poetics, Western theatre thought, Chinese aesthetics and Israeli performance studies. The aim is not to impose an external theory but to disclose the layers of meaning operating within dramatic texts from different critical angles.

Keywords: Maithili drama; theatre; performability; comparative criticism; folk theatre; performance studies

Kunal's *Kusmā-Salhes and Six Other Plays* is a collection of contemporary Maithili drama oriented towards the stage in both its underlying content and its formal design. A critical examination must therefore move beyond the written text to bring acting, performability, audience interaction, music, movement, empty space and the history of performance into focus.

The critical method adopted in this book places four comparative orientations on a single analytical plane: Indian dramaturgy and poetics; Western dramatic thought; Chinese dramatic aesthetics; and Israeli performance studies. They are employed not to demonstrate that these traditions are identical but to distinguish different levels of dramaturgical skill, acting imagery, narrative structure, social meaning and audience experience.

On the Indian side, *rasa*, the distinction between *lokadharmī* and *nāṭyadharmī*, *dhvani*, *vakrokti*, character types and epistemological reasoning become the principal critical tools. On the Western side, concepts such as mimesis, recognition, the alienation effect, metatheatre, the carnivalesque, existentialism, memory and women's agency help us read dramatic action and its social meanings.

Chinese aesthetic perspectives open another approach to structure, the relation between emptiness and fullness, character categories, emotional atmosphere, loyalty, question and answer, and forms of change. Israeli theatre studies are used to consider the representational character of performance, language revival, sacred texts, memory, testimony and cultural self-identification.

The fundamental rule of this method is that theory must not be imposed upon the work. Instead, the questions raised by a play's scenes, dialogue, stage practices and structure should determine the role of theory as a means of investigation. Comparative criticism then ceases to be a display of external names and becomes a disciplined process of opening up the dramatic text's internal structures of meaning.

16. Kunal's Dramaturgy: Folk Theatre, Classical Tradition and Modernity

Abstract

The most distinctive feature of Kunal's theatrical language is its deliberate synthesis of three traditions. On one hand he uses the devices of classical Sanskrit drama—the *pūrvaraṅga*, *sūtradhāra* and actress, and an invocation resembling the *nāndī*; on another, the elements of Mithila's folk theatre (*nāch*)—the *samājī* (chorus), the clown *Vipṭā*, the parrot-narrator, collective song and dance, direct address to the audience, and an open or layered stage …

Keywords: Folk theatre; Nāṭyaśāstra; modern theatre; Brecht; performability; multiple roles

The most distinctive feature of Kunal's theatrical language is its deliberate synthesis of three traditions. First, he adopts the devices of classical Sanskrit drama: the preliminary performance (*pūrvaraṅga*), the *sūtradhāra* and actress, and a benedictory invocation resembling the *nāndī*. Second, he places at the centre the elements of Mithila's folk theatre (*nāch*): the *samājī* (chorus), the clown *Vipṭā*, the parrot-narrator, collective singing and dancing, direct address to the audience, and an open or layered stage. Third, there are the self-referential devices and techniques of "alienation" associated with modern theatre.

On this final point, the Western theory of theatre provides a relevant comparison. Brecht's "epic theatre" and its *Verfremdungseffekt* or alienation effect—through which spectators are repeatedly reminded that they are watching a play—emerge as natural parts of folk form in Kunal's theatre. The bard's account, the relinquishing of roles and the debate over an alternative ending in *Cālis Cor*; Vipṭā's repeated interruption, "Move the cart forward!", in *Bidāpat*; and the metanarrative utterances of Hiraman and Vipṭā in *Kusmā-Salhes* all continually break the "fourth wall". Significantly, what Brecht introduced in the West as an avant-garde experiment was always inherent in Mithila's *nāch*. Kunal brings precisely this indigenous modernity into view.

Kunal's attention to performability is extraordinary. At the end of *Cālis Cor*, he writes that the play has three versions—forty-five minutes, sixty minutes and one hour—and that a fourth version, a thirteen-episode *dhvani-nāṭya* (radio-drama) series, has also been broadcast. He further proposes that one actor may play multiple characters. Such information shows that these plays were written with the practical demands of theatre in mind: they are genuinely performable scripts, not merely imagined possibilities of performance.

17. Kuṇḍaliyā in Laldas's Mithila Ramayana and an Examination of Metre

Abstract

Kuṇḍaliyā in Laldas's Mithila Ramayana, and the disruption of its metre through an editor's or proofreader's lack of knowledge. Laldas's Ramayana is composed in the caupāī form: approximately ninety-five per cent of it consists of caupāī, while the remainder employs the rūpamālā metre and gītikā. Here, however, I discuss the kuṇḍaliyā, which occurs only sparingly but has impressed me deeply.

Keywords: Laldas; Mithila Ramayana; kuṇḍaliyā; metre; critical examination; short vowel.

Kuṇḍaliyā in Laldas's Mithila Ramayana and the Metrical Disruption Caused by an Editor's or Proofreader's Ignorance

1

Laldas's Ramayana was composed in caupāī. Understand that ninety-five per cent of it is in caupāī, while the remaining portions employ the rūpamālā metre and gītikā.

I am, however, concerned here with the kuṇḍaliyā. Although the form appears only rarely, it has made a profound impression upon me. Its character resembles that of the rubāʿī; read Omar Khayyam's rubāʿīyāt and you will begin to love the kuṇḍaliyā.

What is a kuṇḍaliyā? To understand it, you must first understand the dohā and the rolā. In Laldas's Mithila Ramayana, you will find both rolā and dohā in addition to kuṇḍaliyā. The kuṇḍaliyā is their combination.

Dohā

The dohā is a quantitative metre. It consists of two lines and four segments. The first segment contains thirteen mātrās, the second eleven, the third thirteen and the fourth eleven. Neither the first nor the third segment should begin with the jagaṇa (U — U), and the second and fourth segments end in a long syllable followed by a short syllable.

Rolā

The rolā is also a quantitative metre. It has four lines and eight segments. The first segment contains eleven mātrās, the second thirteen, the third eleven, the fourth thirteen, the fifth eleven and the sixth thirteen. The end of the first segment of every line consists of a long–short sequence or three short syllables. The second segment of each line ends in four short syllables, two long syllables, long–short–short (bhagaṇa, — U U), or short–short–long (sagaṇa, U U —). Do not begin a rolā with a short–long–short sequence.

Kuṇḍaliyā

The kuṇḍaliyā is the intertwining, or combination, of dohā and rolā. Compose a dohā; then take its final segment, of eleven mātrās, and make it the first segment of the rolā by repeating it, before appending the remaining rolā. Take care that the first word of the opening segment of the dohā and the last word of the final segment of the rolā are identical. The first and last words of the kuṇḍaliyā are the same. Its fourth and fifth segments are also identical.

2

Let us now turn directly to the end of the Sundara Kāṇḍa of the Mithila Ramayana, where four kuṇḍaliyās are to be found.

Kuṇḍaliyā–Dohā (Maithili Academy Edition)

Raghunayaka, abode of compassion, looked upon the humble Vibhishana.
रघुनायक करुणायतन देखि विभीषण दीन।

He gave the token of kingship; let your mind remain absorbed in his feet.
देल प्रमाणहिं राज्य पद तनि पद रहु मन लीन॥

Let your mind remain absorbed in his feet: he protects the poor and the lowly.
तनि पद रहु मन लीन हीन दीनक प्रतिपालक।

Compassionate to those who seek refuge, he dispels Laldas's sorrow.
शरणागत वत्सल दयाल लालक दुख घालक॥

The guardians of the worlds, Death and Time, fear the sight of his keen arrows.
लोकपाल यम काल डरथि लखि जनिक सुसायक।

He who frees all worlds from sorrow is the mighty Lord Raghunayaka. (1)
सकल लोक निश्शोक करथि से विभु रघुनायक॥१॥

The tale of Raghupati destroys sin; merely hearing it drives away grief.
अधनाशिनी रघुपति कथा, सुनितहि हो दुख दूर।

The Lord remains gracious to them, fulfilling their heart's desires.
तनिपर प्रभु अनुकूल रहि, करथि मनोरथ पूर॥

He fulfils their desires and always protects them from cruel people.
करथि मनोरथ पूर क्रूर सौं सदा बचाबथि।

He increases their wealth, kindred, victory, splendour, fortune and happiness.
धन जन विजय विभूति जूति सुख तनिक बढ़ाबथि॥

He saves them from lust and the like, and grants undying devotion.
काम आदि सौं बचथि भक्ति पाबथि अविनाशिनि।

The sin-destroying Ganga removes all their sins and suffering. (2)
पापताप सभ तनिक हरथि गंगा अघयाशिनी॥२॥

O mind, like a moon-loving cakora, why keep tasting the fierce embers of sensual life?
चितचकोर की चाख नित, विषय विषम अंगार।

Better to worship Sita and Rama: make the nectar of their names your food.
सीतारामक भजन भल, कर फल अमिय अहार॥

Make nectar your food, casting off the burden of worldly existence.
कर फल अमिय अहार भार संसारक छोड़ी।

Devotees break the bonds of becoming and attain the supreme station of Brahman.
लेल सकल पद ब्रह्म भक्त भव बन्धन तोड़ी॥

Even the fallen may find a path, and wherever they dwell may find fitting happiness.
पतितहुँ काँ गति जतय ततय रहि लहु सुख समुचित।

Know what truly serves your good; shun the improper attractions of worldly life. (3)
हित निश्चित निज जानु अपर भव विषयक अनुचित॥३॥

O bird of the mind, how long must you suffer in the cage of worldly existence?
मन विहङ्ग कति दुख सहह भवपिंजर मे आबि।

O Lal, if you wish for happiness, take refuge in the tree of the Lord's feet.
गहह लाल जौं सुख चहय श्रीपद तरुवर पाबि॥

Having found that tree of the Lord's feet, sing the story of Rama every day.
श्रीपद तरुवर पाबि गाबि रहु रामकथा नित।

There is no other means so suited to welfare and deliverance.
नहि तेहि सौं अछि अपर युक्ति कल्याण त्राण हित॥

How many sinners have crossed the ocean of becoming without lingering a moment?
कत पातकि भव सिन्धु तरल नहि रहल एक क्षण।

Sing Hari's story again and again, gathering your mind into one as best you can. (4)
गाबि गाबि हरि कथा यथा मति लाबि एक मन॥४॥

The text reproduced above is taken from the Maithili Academy's edition.

3

Quantitative Scansion

Let us consider Maithili pronunciation rules and the distinction between short and long vowels.

Acquaint yourself with the prosodic categories called *guru* and *laghu* in the śāstras.

Among the thirteen vowel signs, अ, इ, उ, ऋ and ऌ are short, while आ, ई, ऊ, ॠ, ए, ऐ, ओ and औ are long. When a vowel is joined to a consonant, a *guṇitākṣara*, or syllabic consonant-vowel unit, is produced: क् + अ = क; क् + आ = का. One vowel or one such consonant-vowel unit constitutes an *akṣara*. An isolated consonant is not counted as an akṣara. Thus in the word अवाक् there are two akṣaras: अ and वा. (1) Every short vowel, and every consonant-vowel unit containing one, is *laghu*; its sign is U, written above it. (2) Every long vowel, and every unit containing a long vowel, is *guru*, represented by a short horizontal mark above it. (3) Every akṣara with anusvāra or visarga is counted as guru. (4) When a conjunct consonant, or a consonant alone, follows an akṣara, that preceding akṣara counts as guru; for example, in अच् and सत्य, अ and स respectively are guru.

Just as an akṣara with anusvāra or visarga is counted as long, a short vowel with candrabindu is counted as short.

That is, candrabindu + short vowel = one mātrā.

Conjunct consonants: here the mātrās are to be counted as follows:

क्ति = क् + त् + इ = 0 + 0 + 1 = 1.

क्ती = क् + त् + ई = 0 + 0 + 2 = 2.

क्ष = क् + ष = 0 + 1.

त्र = त् + र = 0 + 1.

ज्ञ = ज् + ञ = ० + १.

श्र = श् + र = ० + १.

स्र = स् + र = ० + १.

शृ = श् + ऋ = ० + १.

त्व = त् + व = ० + १.

त्त्व = त् + त् + व = ० + ० + १.

Short vowel + ऽ = १ + ०.

The *bikārī* sign is not used after अ or a long vowel: दिअऽ, आऽ and ओऽ, for example, are faulty usages. It can, however, be placed after a consonant combined with अ.

Short vowel + candrabindu = १ + ०.
Long vowel + candrabindu = २ + ०.
For example, हँसल = १ + १ + १.

साँस = २ + १.

The *bikārī* mark and candrabindu each have a count of zero.
जा कऽ = २ + १.

क् = ०.

क = क् + अ = ० + १.

Because a tendency has developed in Maithili to read क as क्, the *bikārī* sign has become necessary. No such need arises with long vowels.
U — sign of a short syllable.
। — sign of a long syllable.

One long syllable (।) equals two short syllables (U).

4

Metrical Disruption

Let us now examine all four kuṇḍaliyās in Laldas's Mithila Ramayana. You will plainly encounter metrical disruption. The poet Laldas himself could not have broken the metre. These are clearly not merely typing mistakes. They may therefore be the work of an editor or proofreader at the Maithili

Academy who, unfamiliar with quantitative scansion, disturbed the metre in an attempt to standardise spelling. Ramdev Jha, however, asserted that no metrical disruption occurs in the Sahitya Akademi edition of Laldas's Ramayana, which he edited. In his reply to the accusation that he had altered the original text, he argued that those making the accusation appeared unfamiliar with quantitative scansion. He maintained that his departures from the source text were intended to correct metrical disruption. In other words, if Laldas wrote in the kuṇḍaliyā metre, an editor should at least know that merely placing the heading 'kuṇḍaliyā' over a poem is insufficient. In Ramdev Jha's view, the Sahitya Akademi edition of Laldas's Ramayana should be treated as the definitive text. Let us now examine that edition.

Laldas's Kuṇḍaliyās, Edited by Ramdev Jha (Sahitya Akademi)

Kuṇḍaliyā–Dohā

Raghunayaka, abode of compassion, looked upon the humble Vibhishana.
रघुनायक करुणायतन देखि विभीषण दीन।

He gave the token of kingship; let your mind remain absorbed in his feet.
देल प्रमाणहिं राज्य पद तनि पद रहु मन लीन॥

Let your mind remain absorbed in his feet: he protects the poor and the lowly.
तनि पद रहु मन लीन हीन दीनक प्रतिपालक।

Compassionate to those who seek refuge, he dispels Laldas's sorrow.
शरणागत वत्सल दयाल लालक दुख घालक॥

The guardians of the worlds, Death and Time, fear the sight of his keen arrows.
लोकपाल यम काल डरथि लखि जनिक सुसायक।

He who frees all worlds from sorrow is the mighty Lord Raghunayaka. (1)
सकल लोक निश्शोक करथि से विभु रघुनायक॥१॥

The tale of Raghupati destroys sin; merely hearing it drives away grief.
अधनाशिनी रघुपति कथा, सुनितहि हो दुख दूर।

The Lord remains gracious to them, fulfilling their heart's desires.
तनिपर प्रभु अनुकूल रहि, करथि मनोरथ पूर॥

He fulfils their desires and always protects them from cruel people.
करथि मनोरथ पूर क्रूर सौं सदा बचाबथि।

He increases their wealth, kindred, victory, splendour, fortune and happiness.
धन जन विजय विभूति जूति सुख तनिक बढ़ाबथि॥

He saves them from lust and the like, and grants undying devotion.
काम आदि सौं बचथि भक्ति पाबथि अविनाशिनि।

The sin-destroying Ganga removes all their sins and suffering. (2)
पापताप सभ तनिक हरथि गंगा अघनाशिनी॥२॥

O mind, like a moon-loving cakora, why keep tasting the fierce embers of sensual life?
चितचकोर की चाख नित, विषय विषम अंगार।

Better to worship Sita and Rama: make the nectar of their names your food.
सीतारामक भजन भल, कर फल अमिय अहार॥

Make nectar your food, casting off the burden of worldly existence.
कर फल अमिय अहार भार संसारक छोड़ी।

Devotees break the bonds of becoming and attain the supreme station of Brahman.
लेल सकल पद ब्रह्म भक्त भव बन्धन तोड़ी॥

Even the fallen may find a path, and wherever they dwell may find fitting happiness.
पतितहुँ काँ गति जतय ततय रहि लहु सुख समुचित।

Know what truly serves your good; shun the improper attractions of worldly life. (3)
हित निश्चित निज जानु अपर भव विषयक अनुचित॥३॥

O bird of the mind, how long must you suffer in the cage of worldly existence?
मन विहङ्ग कति दुख सहह भवपिंजर मे आबि।

O Lal, if you wish for happiness, take refuge in the tree of the Lord's feet.
गहह लाल जौं सुख चहय श्रीपद तरुवर पाबि॥

Having found that tree of the Lord's feet, sing the story of Rama every day.
श्रीपद तरुवर पाबि गाबि रहु रामकथा नित।

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नहि तेहि सौं अछि अपर युक्ति कल्याण त्राण हित॥

How many sinners have crossed the ocean of becoming without lingering a moment?
कत पातकि भव सिन्धु तरल नहि रहल एक क्षण।

Sing Hari's story again and again, gathering your mind into one as best you can. (4)
गाबि गाबि हरि कथा यथा मति लाबि एक मन॥४॥

There is, in fact, little substantial difference between the Maithili Academy's text and this edition. Only case endings and a couple of words have been joined together at some places and separated at others. The last word of the second kuṇḍaliyā has been changed from अघयाशिनी (*aghayāśinī*) to अघनाशिनी (*aghanāśinī*).

Gokarna in Karnataka lies beside the Gangavali and Adhanashini streams, and 'पापताप सभ तनिक हरथि गंगा' refers to a Ganga that removes sins; therefore the use of 'अधनाशिनी' (*adhanāśinī*) is appropriate, not 'अघनासिनी' (*aghanāsinī*), which is probably a typing error.

Although the claim to have corrected the metrical irregularities has not been substantiated, I find the Sahitya Akademi text preferable to the Maithili Academy text because an attempt has been made to use words appropriately.

18. Language, Metre and Poetic Beauty: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti

Abstract

This chapter examines the dramatic functions of folk idiom, Sanskrit-derived mythological diction, songs, Vidyapati's lyric verses, double meaning, dhvani and vakrokti in Kunal's plays. Language here is not decoration; it is an active theatrical means of constructing character, setting, memory and emotional register.

Keywords: Maithili language; metre; rasa; dhvani; vakrokti; Vidyapati; dramatic poetry.

Kunal's language is not uniform but multilayered. In the trilogy of folk plays, he uses distinctly rural Maithili idioms, heavily alliterative rhymes and song forms, with folk expressions of *hāsya* (the comic) and *śṛṅgāra* (the erotic or romantic) predominating. In the quartet of love plays, he adopts a comparatively Sanskritised, classical and cultivated Maithili appropriate to an āśrama setting and mythological dignity. His sensitivity to character and milieu is clearly reflected in this linguistic artistry.

From the perspective of *vakrokti*, the folk plays bring verbal obliqueness—Kuntaka's sense of the term—to its highest pitch. The chieftain's turban (*saradārīk mureṭhā*), Kusma's *lahaṭhī* (shackles versus bangles), *cumāon* versus *śrāddha*, and the epithet 'supreme rogue' (*dhūrta-śiromaṇi*) generate dramatic energy through double meanings and puns. From the standpoint of *dhvani*, the ending of *Bidāpat* (life within the *pada*, or lyric) and the repeated love refrain of *Kusmā-Salhes* rise above direct denotation into suggested meaning: tranquillity resonates beneath pathos, while spirituality sounds above erotic love.

Kunal's deployment of Vidyapati's lyrics is a deliberate poetic strategy. It is not simply ornamentation but an effort to turn Mithila's poetic memory into a living component of theatre. In *Bidāpat*, he creates a dramatic interpretation of Vidyapati's lyrics; in *Sukanyā*, a lyric of spring becomes an instrument for creating atmosphere. Thus the traditions of lyric poetry and drama merge into one another.

19. The Ideological Ground: A Parallel Literary Perspective and Theatre

Abstract

This chapter considers the presence of folk performers, marginalised communities, women's agency and cultural synthesis in Kunal's dramatic practice from the perspective of parallel literature. The ideological orientation of his theatre appears not as slogans but as a socially engaged rereading enacted through stories, characters, folk forms and theatrical practice.

Keywords: parallel literature; folk theatre; subaltern; women's agency; cultural synthesis; Mithila.

The importance of this collection emerges particularly clearly from the perspective of the Videha parallel-literature movement. Whereas institutional literary histories have generally privileged elite-centred, printed and supposedly 'refined' traditions, Kunal grounds his entire dramatic undertaking in folk theatre and oral narrative. In his dedication he brings to the centre of literary history the unnamed performers of *nāch* whose names have never been recorded.

The clearest expression of this perspective is his portrayal in *Kusmā-Salhes* of the Dusadh (Dalit) folk-deity hero as a people's hero and a symbol of fearlessness and freedom. This establishes a subaltern voice upon the stage. In *Bidāpat*, the great poet Vidyapati is brought down from the pedestal of an institutional icon and made a living protagonist of folk theatre. In the quartet of love plays, mythological heroines—Śruvāvatī, Sukanyā, Śvetā and Suprabhā—are reread as women capable of acting and determining their own lives. These are different dimensions of the same parallel-historical perspective.

Resistance on three levels—caste (Dalit and subaltern), gender (women's agency), and culture (Hindu–Muslim synthesis)—operates simultaneously in these plays. Nowhere, however, does it assume the form of sloganeering; instead it is absorbed into the natural movement of folk forms. This is evidence of Kunal's ideological maturity.

Part II

Applied Theatre Criticism

Society, Identity and Cultural Criticism

20. Towards a Woman-Centred Critical Theory for Maithili (Including Queer Feminism): With Reference to Kamini's *A Woman Divided into Fragments* and Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's *Lesbian Continuum*

Abstract

A woman-centred critical theory for Maithili, including queer feminism, with reference to Kamini's *A Woman Divided into Fragments* and Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's *Lesbian Continuum*: (1) a review of Kamini's poetry collection *A Woman Divided into Fragments*; and (2) an evaluation of Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's *Lesbian Continuum* and a comparative analysis with Kamini.

Keywords: women; centred; critical theory; queer; feminism; including; reference; Kamini.

Towards a Woman-Centred Critical Theory for Maithili (Including Queer Feminism)

With Reference to Kamini's *A Woman Divided into Fragments* and Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's *Lesbian Continuum*

1. *A Woman Divided into Fragments*: A Review of Kamini's Poetry Collection. 2. Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's *Lesbian Continuum*: Review and Comparative Analysis with Kamini.

1

A Woman Divided into Fragments: A Review of Kamini's Poetry Collection

Introduction: The Profound Meaning of the Title

Kamini's collection of poems *A Woman Divided into Fragments* (2017) is an important document of feminist consciousness in modern Maithili poetry. Its very title is a powerful poetic statement: how a woman's existence is progressively fragmented in a patriarchal society; how, divided among her different roles—as wife, mother, daughter, sister and daughter-in-law—she loses her original identity. This fragmentation is psychological as well as social.

A Woman Divided into Fragments (Title Poem)

This is the collection's central poem, presenting the tragedy of the fragmentation of a woman's existence:

> 'Along with a woman's body / now her womb and her milk / are also being sold. / A woman returns having sold / even her motherly love, / who knows out of what necessity.'

Principal Features:

The many dimensions of fragmentation: the poem speaks not merely of bodily division but also of mental and emotional disintegration.

Representation of inner struggle: how a woman loses her original self amid her various roles.

> The compassionate voice: 'She was not / so hard before, / or have we made her so?' These lines also establish society's responsibility.

Tears

This poem symbolises a woman's silent suffering:

> 'Whenever tears / fall from a woman's eyes, / they are not merely / a few drops of water; / they stand / against injustice and oppression.'

Literary Qualities:

Symbolism: tears are not simply tears; they signify rebellion.

Social commentary: men's lack of sensitivity ('She was not / so hard before').

> Interrogative intensity: 'How did the power / to shake things disappear?'

What an Irony!

A forceful satire on the paradoxes of women's education:

> 'He who hides his face / in a woman's sari-end, / he who exploits / a woman's body, / he who cannot live / without a woman— / that same man calls / a woman's dignity and honour / into question.'

Poetic Craft:

Use of alliteration: 'मुँह छुपबैत' (*mūh chupabait*), 'कुलटा अछि' (*kulṭā achi*), and 'नरकक खान अछि' (*narakak khān achi*).

Parallel structure: the repetition of three questioning lines.

Biting satire: a severe critique of men's double standards.

The Inner Mind

A poem offering a profound psychoanalytic exploration of love:

> 'If you love / a woman, / do so not in the darkness / of night, / but in the light / of day.'

Distinctive Qualities:

Ethical clarity: love should be open, not concealed.

Social responsibility: a love answerable before society.

Emotional depth: the true meaning of intimacy.

Brahmavākya

A sharp criticism of patriarchal religious structures:

'Sakina Khatun / is very sad today; / time and again / her eyes fill with tears.'

Principal Elements:

Historical reference: the story of Sakina Khatun.

Religious criticism: the hypocrisy of the man who has 'a house full of children and family'.

Feminist discourse: the exploitation of women in the name of religion.

Punarnavā

A powerful poem of self-reconstruction:

'Today I offered / sesame and kuśa grass / in your name; / I bathed and returned / from midstream. / From today, you have become / the past for me.'

Poetic Features:

Use of metaphor: sesame and kuśa grass, the flowing current, and symbols of womanhood.

Declaration of self-respect: the rejection of male-centred identity.

Beauty of diction: the use of a folk tradition involving sesame and kuśa grass.

The Trial by Fire

A contemporary rereading of Sita's ordeal by fire in the Ramayana:

'Why should a woman / suffer the punishment / for a man's mistake? / Why must Sita alone / undergo the trial by fire / again and again— / the customs and rules / of society?'

Important Aspects:

Mythological reinterpretation: questioning Sita's trial by fire.

The demand for gender justice: why was the man not subjected to a trial by fire?

Social criticism: opposition to double standards.

A Woman's Destiny

A philosophical consideration of the social destiny of women:

'By returning once again / into the womb of the earth, / you did not do well, Sita; / you closed it off / for ever and ever.'

Philosophical Depth:

Questioning fatalism: is a woman's destiny predetermined or imposed by society?

Mythological reference: Sita's return into the earth.

Compassion and rebellion: an effective presentation of mingled emotions.

Two Fistfuls of Paddy

A moving portrayal of economic exploitation:

> 'My heart finds comfort: / this grove of mango saplings / was planted by my own father; / this is the house / built by my father.'

Principal Features:

The question of economic rights: women's rights to property.

Emotional intensity: memories of ancestral property.

Social realism: criticism of the custom of *kanyādān*, the ritual 'giving away' of a daughter.

A Woman's Patience

A powerful depiction of the limits of endurance:

> 'Is being a woman / a small thing? / It is no small or great matter, / and so— / and so a woman must pay / the penalty / for being a woman.'

Literary Qualities:

Ironic expression: 'must pay the penalty'.

Logical progression: the gradual development of an argument.

Emotional intensity: the breaking point of patience.

Another Krishna

A depiction of the complexity of modern relationships:

> 'Madhava! How did you forget / that I am your very Radha, / whom you once / called your own?'

Principal Elements:

Mythological parallel: Radha and Krishna in a contemporary context.

The irony of love: the pain of abandonment.

> Interrogative intensity: 'This Vaṃśīvaṭa, / this Vrindavan— / today all are silent.'

Kanyādān Means Bathing in the Ganga

A forceful rejection of the custom of *kanyādān*:

> '*Kanyādān* is still performed / among us today: / Father, holding barley and kuśa grass / in his hand, / places his daughter's hand / in another man's hand.'

Distinctive Qualities:

Redefining tradition: is *kanyādān* to be equated with bathing in the Ganga?

Criticism of patriarchy: the objectification of the daughter.

Declaration of self-respect: 'If I had done it, what would I have done?'

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Sesame and Rice

A symbolic poem of women's freedom:

Mother would never let her daughter eat sesame and rice during the Tila Sankranti festival. She would distribute it throughout the neighbourhood, saying that a daughter's life was burdensome enough already; why make her indebted by feeding her sesame?

Poetic Craft:

Use of folk tradition: the symbol of sesame and rice.

Social commentary: the denial of women's rights.

Symbolism: sesame and rice as an emblem of women's freedom.
".

I Am Not a Purchased Slave

A manifesto rejecting servitude:

> 'Mother will spend her whole life / beside Father, / as his bonded labourer.'

Principal Features:

Declaration of self-respect: 'I am not a purchased slave.'

Generational difference: the mother's sacrifice against the daughter's rebellion.

The aspiration for social change: the dream of a new age.

...

Uts

The conflict between memory and the present:

> 'I am not merely your wife / I am something more / such as someone's mother / someone's sister / someone's daughter.'

Literary features:

Multidimensional identity: the diverse roles of a woman.

Self-exploration: 'What I am saying.'

Emotional complexity: the conflict between memory and the present.
"

Muffler

A portrayal of the ironies of urban life:

> 'Today I bought a muffler / today I saw a muffler / and then I remembered.'

Principal elements:

" Criticism of materialism: the emptiness of urban life.

The significance of memory: the sweetness of village life.

Comparative analysis: city versus village.

“

Man, Woman's Creation

A philosophical consideration of relations between women and men:

> 'Whenever sweat falls / from a man's forehead / a woman will wipe it / with the end of her sari.'

Philosophical depth:

A philosophy of coexistence: the mutual dependence of women and men.

The power of tenderness: the significance of a woman's affection.

The demand for equality: 'For man / is woman's creation.'

Draupadi–1

A contemporary rereading of Draupadi from the Mahabharata:

> 'Draupadi! Into how many fragments / must your feelings have been divided / on that day / when they were split into fragments ...'

Literary merits:

Mythic reinterpretation: a modern perspective on Draupadi.

Questioning polyandry: five husbands = fragmentation.

The crisis of female identity: a divided existence.

Draupadi–2

The contemporary relevance of Draupadi's disrobing:

> 'Draupadi! I feel uneasy / bearing the weight of your unbound hair.'

Principal features:

The symbolism of disrobing: the exploitation of women in modern times.

The absence of Krishna: the absence of a protector.

The need for inner strength: the resolve to fight for oneself.

The Heirloom Sari

An incisive critique of social conventions:

> 'Yashoda Ji's “that” / government officer / every day, as soon as he opens his eyes.'

Distinctive merits:

A satirical tone: 'Yashoda Ji's.'

The exposure of social hypocrisy: religious pretence.

Resistance to traditions hostile to women: control even after death.

Without a Relationship

A portrayal of the hollowness of modern relationships:

> 'The rose you gave me / has withered / even its leaves have dried / its fragrance had vanished long before.'

Literary features:

Symbolism: the rose = love.

A portrayal of decay: the death of a relationship.
Emotional emptiness: 'has withered.'

The Speed of Time

A poignant presentation of time's cruelty:

'Forgive me, Mother / at this fourth stage of life / when you need me.'

Principal elements:

Generational conflict: the mother's old age.
Social responsibility: neglect within the family.
Compassion and helplessness: 'illness and old age.'

How Deeply I Miss My Home

An emotional expression of the pain of migration:

'Somewhere here / was my home / which can no longer be seen.'

Poetic beauty:

Nostalgia: the memory of home.
The pain of displacement: a life lived away from home.
The significance of intimacy: home = belonging.

The Abandoned Woman

A philosophical consideration of the cruelty of fate:

'Why is it always / the woman who is abandoned / why is the man never abandoned?'

Distinctive merits:

The question of gender inequality:

Why is it the woman who is abandoned?
Philosophical depth: fate versus society.
An interrogative impulse: a succession of pointed questions.

This Is Not Right, Noble One

A bold attempt to reread the Ramayana:

'Abandonment in love / is not right, noble one / you were known as ...'

Principal features:

Reassessment of a mythological character: criticism of Rama.
A feminist perspective: taking Sita's side.
Bold questioning: redefining *maryada*, the bounds of righteous conduct.

I Shall Fight

A powerful affirmation of inner strength:

'I shall fight / to the very end / for as long as life remains.'

Literary merits:

A resolve to struggle: a lifelong fight.
An assertion of self-confidence: a woman.

An inspiring voice: hope for the future.

Chandai

A beautiful use of the folk tradition:

> 'When Chandai became anxious / on her first journey to her husband's home ...'

Distinctive merits:

The influence of folk poetry: Chandai's story.

Social reality: conflicts within the family.

Emotional beauty: memory and the present.

Has Such a Thing Ever Happened?

An aspiration for social change:

> 'O God! Punamiya will not survive / this time.'

Principal elements:

Rejection of rebirth: 'This life is much ...'

A compassionate voice: the depth of suffering.

Spiritual questioning: a complaint addressed to God.

Neglected

The psychological effects of neglect:

> 'Some things become bound / to life in such a way / that those very things become paramount.'

Literary features:

Subtle psychological analysis: the effects of neglect.

Emotional depth: 'My elder sister gave me my name.'

Self-exploration: the search for one's identity.

Gita

A poetic presentation of a philosophy of life:

> 'Crushed beneath a mountain / of responsibilities is Gita / with four daughters, all four of them girls.'

Principal features:

Social responsibility: the burden borne by a woman.

A compassionate portrayal: a mountain of responsibilities.

A Life Torn to Shreds

A poignant portrayal of life's disintegration:

> 'The first time / I placed my hand / in your hand.'

Literary merits:

The conflict between memory and the present: the memory of love.

The pain of disintegration: 'a life torn to shreds.'

Emotional intensity: the *karuna rasa*, or aesthetic mood of pathos.

Even After All This

Resistance to social convention:

'When the sweat from her forehead / falls down to her feet / who knows where a woman can go?'

Distinctive merits:

Recognition of labour: neglect of women's work.

Gender inequality: male privilege.

Incisive questioning: 'any story.'

Silence

A philosophical consideration of the power of silence:

'Your love / is not a rose petal / nor is it a thorn of the *bagur* plant.'

Philosophical depth:

The significance of silence: love beyond words.

The expression of subtle feelings: 'loving me.'

Symbolism: silence = profound love.

Broken Strings

The ironies of modern life:

'Like inflation, illness and unemployment / for me ...'

Principal elements:

Social reality: the burden of rising prices.

Economic crisis: unemployment.

A compassionate portrayal: the struggle of life.

Paro

A powerful declaration of women's independence:

'Paro is grown up now / she makes her own decisions / for herself.'

Literary features:

The right to self-determination: independent decisions.

Social transformation: the arrival of a new age.

An optimistic voice: the dream of the future.

Carefree Laughter

A beautiful portrayal of motherhood:

'Like a lotus flower / Prachi bursts into laughter.'

Poetic beauty:

Nature imagery: the simile of the lotus.

The joy of motherhood: bursting into laughter.

Tender feeling: the expression of affection.

Woman and the Buddha

The question of spiritual equality:

'Better one sorrow / than these hundred sorrows / it would have been better / had I become a Buddha.'

Philosophical depth:

The spiritual quest: the longing for liberation.
The gender question: why should a woman not become a Buddha?
A demand for equality: spiritual rights.

From Beginning to End

A philosophical consideration of the cycle of life:

'Like the roots of the banyan and peepal / I have not spread so far ...'

Principal features:

The symbol of nature: the roots of banyan and peepal trees.
Self-exploration: the search for existence.
Philosophical questioning: the meaning of life.

Resistance

A powerful declaration of rebellion:

'Like a blue celestial sheet / spread across / my entire existence ...'

Literary merits:

The resolve to resist: opposition to exploitation.
An assertion of inner strength: 'What am I to do?'
An optimistic voice: faith in the future.

Mother

A poignant portrayal of motherhood:

'How wonderful it would be / if mothers / never grew old.'

Principal elements:

A mother's sacrifice: lifelong self-denial.
The depth of compassion: a portrayal of intimacy.
Social commentary: the neglect of mothers.

Hypocrisy

An incisive critique of religious hypocrisy:

'Sarcastically chanting / "A woman's character and a man's destiny ..."'

Distinctive merits:

Religious criticism: a rereading of scripture.
Exposing misogynistic thinking: unmasking hypocrisy.
A satirical tone: intense indignation.

Liberation

A poetic expression of the longing for liberation:

'With great devotion / Punita has performed / her father's *shraddha* rites.'

Literary features:

Religious redefinition: women's rights.

Social change: breaking with tradition.

An assertion of self-confidence: the path to liberation.

Of What Use Is Such Valour?

A redefinition of *purushartha*, human endeavour or manly virtue:

'O grandsire Bhishma of society / how long will you remain silent?'

Principal elements:

Questioning *purushartha*: what use is such valour?

Criticism of social neglect: why this silence?

The demand for gender equality: equal rights.

From Poison to More Poison

A psychological analysis of life's poison:

'O, one who has been scorched! / It is by this name / that you are known ...'

Literary merits:

Psychological depth: the effect of poison.

Self-exploration: a crisis of identity.

Philosophical questioning: the meaning of life.

Existence

A philosophical consideration of existence:

'However hard you try to erase it / my existence will not be erased.'

Philosophical depth:

Existential thought: an independent existence.

An assertion of inner strength: an indelible presence.

A rebellious voice: opposition to exploitation.

The Laughter of Tuberoses

An outstanding example of poetic beauty:

'When I close my eyes / I cannot see anything anywhere.'

Poetic beauty:

Nature imagery: the symbolism of the tuberose.

The expression of subtle feeling: laughter in darkness.

An element of mystery: profound meaning.

The Weapon of Trust

A philosophical consideration of the significance of trust:

'Here, too, / there is no relationship / between a man's words and the man.'

Principal features:

A crisis of trust: a man's promises.

Social reality: the dominance of falsehood.

A compassionate voice: betrayal of trust.

The Relationship Between Flower and Branch

A philosophical analysis of relationships:

'The flower asks the branch / between you and me ...'

Philosophical depth:

The nature of a relationship: the symbols of flower and branch.

Mutual dependence: coexistence.

The philosophy of nature: the truth of life.

Midstream

A poignant portrayal of life's struggle:

'Today / the sixteenth year of marriage / is passing.'

Literary merits:

The cruelty of time: counting the years.

A portrayal of isolation: the pain of loneliness.

Karuna rasa: profound suffering.

The Unborn–1

A poignant portrayal of an unborn child:

'Sobbing in little gasps / Devaki is weeping ...'

Principal elements:

The pain of motherhood: the killing of an unborn child.

Social reality: female foeticide.

A compassionate portrayal: a moving expression.

The Unborn–2

A strong protest against female foeticide:

'O my father / if upon your forehead ...'

Distinctive merits:

Social criticism: opposition to the preference for sons.

Exposing patriarchy: gender discrimination.

Logical progression: arguments developed step by step.

The Bazaar of Women's Bodies

An incisive criticism of the objectification of women:

'This society / will have to change.'

Literary features:

Opposition to objectification: the trade in women's bodies.
A demand for social transformation: the need for revolutionary change.
Intense indignation: a satirical voice.

Honour

A powerful declaration of self-respect:

'Just as we plant / holy basil in a flowerpot ...'

Principal features:

The importance of self-respect: safeguarding personal dignity.
Social reality: the tension between honour and humiliation.
Symbolism: the worship of holy basil.

Overall Evaluation

A Woman Divided into Fragments: A Multidimensional Critical Analysis

Introduction: The Need for an Interdisciplinary Perspective

Kamini's poetry collection *Khand-Khand Me Bantait Stri* (*A Woman Divided into Fragments*, 2017) is not merely a literary work; it is a complex network of epistemological, socio-political, and aesthetic questions. Four principal analytical frameworks are necessary for a proper evaluation of this work:

1. Gangesha's Navya-Nyaya philosophy: an epistemological foundation and the theory of valid means of knowledge.

2. The Videha parallel-history framework: its place in the Maithili literary tradition.

3. Indian aesthetics: theories of *rasa*, *dhvani*, *vakrokti*, and *aucitya*.

4. Western and Chinese theories: feminism, postcolonialism, and Taoist philosophy.

Section 1: An Evaluation through Gangesha's Navya-Nyāya Philosophy

1.1 Gangesha's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* and the Epistemology of Poetry

The development of the theory of the means of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*) in Gangesha Upadhyaya's (1325 CE) *Tattvacintāmaṇi* is highly relevant to the analysis of the structure of poetic knowledge. According to Gangesha, there are four means of valid knowledge:

1.1.1 Perception (*pratyakṣa pramāṇa*)

Gangesha's definition: "इन्द्रियार्थसन्निकर्षोत्पन्नं ज्ञानम् अव्यपदेश्यं व्यवसायात्मकं प्रत्यक्षम्" (knowledge arising from contact between a sense organ and its object, inexpressible through words and determinate, is perception).

Kamini's poetry presents knowledge arising from direct experience:

In the poem 'Two Fistfuls of Paddy':

My heart finds comfort.

These are the young rice shoots planted

by my own father.

This is not merely memory; it is immediate, direct experience. According to Gangesha, there is a distinction between indeterminate perception (*nirvikalpaka*, without conceptual determination) and determinate perception (*savikalpaka*, with conceptual determination). Kamini's poetry presents determinate perception, in which sensory experience, joined with dispositions and memories, gives rise to poetic knowledge.

1.1.2 Inference (*anumāna pramāṇa*)

Gangesha's principle of invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*): "व्याप्तिर्हि अविनाभावः साध्यसाधनयोः" (pervasion is the inseparable connection between what is to be proved and the means of proving it).

In the poem 'Trial by Fire':

Why must a woman bear the punishment
for a man's mistake?
Why must Sita undergo a trial by fire
again and again?

This constitutes a structure of inferential reasoning:

Reason (*hetu*): Sita repeatedly underwent trial by fire.

Pervasion (*vyāpti*): wherever a male-dominated society exists, women are exploited.

Locus (*pakṣa*): Mithila society.

Probandum (*sādhya*): patriarchal exploitation.

According to Gangesha's five-membered syllogism (*pañcāvayava-nyāya*):

1. Proposition (*pratijñā*): women are exploited.

2. Reason (*hetu*): because Sita underwent a trial by fire.

3. Example (*udāharaṇa*): wherever patriarchy exists, women are exploited (as in Draupadi's disrobing).

4. Application (*upanaya*): patriarchy exists in Mithila.

5. Conclusion (*nigamana*): therefore, women are exploited in Mithila.

1.1.3 Analogy (*upamāna pramāṇa*)

Gangesha's theory of analogy: "तत्त्वज्ञानम् उपमानं साधारणधर्मकथनात्" (knowledge of the object through a statement of a shared characteristic).

In the poem 'Man, Woman's Creation':

Whenever sweat falls
from a man's forehead,
a woman will wipe it
with the end of her sari.

This is an analogy based on partial similarity. The relationship between woman and man ought to rest on complementarity, not exploitation. This is an excellent example of Gangesha's consideration of similarity and dissimilarity (*sādharmya–vaidharmya-vicāra*).

1.1.4 Testimony (*śabda pramāṇa*)

Gangesha's principle of the trustworthy utterance: "आप्तवचनं शब्दः" (the words of a reliable authority constitute verbal testimony).

Kamini's poetry questions both popular sayings and religious scripture:

In the poem 'Hypocrisy':

"त्रिया चरित्रम्पुरुषस्य भाग्यम्" ('A woman's character and a man's destiny ...').

Chanting with sarcasm,
a whole palmful

of vermilion spots.

This amounts to a refutation of scriptural verbal testimony. According to Gangesha, trustworthiness is necessary for the validity of testimony. Kamini raises the question: is this scriptural saying trustworthy? Does it communicate true knowledge?

1.2 Gangesha's Theory of Indeterminate Perception and Women's Identity

According to Gangesha's theory of indeterminate perception, the first stage of knowledge is free from concepts. Similarly, a woman's initial experience of her own identity should not be defined by men; it should be self-determined.

In the poem 'This Is Not Right, Noble One':

Abandonment in love

is not right, noble one;

you were called

the supreme exemplar of righteous conduct.

This refutes a male-defined conception of *maryādā*, or righteous conduct. In Gangesha's terminology, it is erroneous cognition (*asat-khyāti*): Sita's self-validity is denied and a Rama-defined 'purity' is imposed upon her.

1.3 Gangesha's Means of Cognising Pervasion and the Logical Structure of Poetry

Gangesha offers three means of apprehending *vyāpti*, or pervasion:

1. *Anvaya* (positive concomitance).
2. *Vyatireka* (negative concomitance).
3. *Anvaya–vyatireka* (the combined method).

In the poem 'The Abandoned Woman':

Why is it always

the woman who is abandoned?

Why is the man never the abandoned one?

This is reasoning by the method of difference (*vyatireka*):

Positive concomitance (*anvaya*): wherever there is a woman, there is abandonment.

Negative concomitance (*vyatireka*): wherever there is a man, abandonment is absent.

Conclusion: the situation is gender-specific, not universal.

1.4 Gangesha's Theory of Error (*khyāti-vāda*) and Poetic Truth

According to Gangesha's theory of cognition contrary to reality (*viparīta-khyāti-vāda*), error consists in superimposing one object upon another.

In the title poem 'A Woman Divided into Fragments':

Together with a woman's body,

there are now being sold
her womb and her milk as well.

Society's deluded knowledge does not see a woman in the wholeness of her existence; instead it imposes upon her a set of fragmented roles:

Mother = womb and milk.
Wife = body and service.
Daughter = burden and gift in marriage.

This is erroneous cognition (*asat-khyāti*): the fragmentation of a woman's unified being is a false superimposition.

1.5 Gangesha's Theory of Absence and the Absence of Women

Gangesha recognises four kinds of absence:

1. *Prāg-abhāva* (prior non-existence).
2. *Pradhvaṃsa-abhāva* (posterior non-existence).
3. *Atyanta-abhāva* (absolute non-existence).
4. *Anyonyābhāva* (mutual non-existence).

In the poem 'I Am Not a Purchased Slave':

Mother will spend her whole life
beside Father,
as his bonded labourer.

This is a rejection of absolute non-existence: the perpetual absence of women's freedom cannot be accepted. The modern woman brings prior non-existence to an end: freedom that did not exist before now exists.

1.6 Gangesha's Principle of Non-Apprehension as Evidence and Poetic Silence

According to Gangesha's theory of non-apprehension as a proof of absence, knowledge may also be possible in the absence of an effective means of proof.

In the poem 'Silence':

Not a rose petal
is your love,
nor a thorn of the *bagur* plant.

This is the evidentiary force of silence. What has not been said may also be known through non-apprehension. In Gangesha's words, "योग्य-अनुपलब्धिःअभाव-प्रतीतेः कारणम्"—the appropriate non-apprehension of a thing is the cause of cognition of its absence.

Section 2: The Videha Parallel-History Framework

2.1 The Character and Objectives of the Videha Movement

The Videha e-journal (since 2000) has sought to establish a parallel history of Maithili literature, offering an alternative to the institutional canon of the Sahitya Akademi.

The fundamental principles of Videha's parallel history are:

1. Democratic literary creation: publication without institutional approval.
2. Representation across social groups: Dalit, women's and Adivasi voices.
3. A counter-canon: a system of recognition parallel to that of the Sahitya Akademi.
4. Digital inclusiveness: dissemination free of physical boundaries.

2.2 Kamini as a Representative of the Videha Tradition

Kamini's poetry collection embodies the central characteristics of the Videha tradition:

2.2.1 Resistance to Institutions and an Independent Voice

In the poem "Hypocrisy":

> "Triyā charitram puruṣasya bhāgyam"
> Chanted with irony.

This is a repudiation of religious and institutional knowledge. The Videha tradition questions the authority of scripture, just as Kamini resists a religion defined by men.

2.2.2 Representation of Subaltern Voices

Videha answers Gayatri Spivak's question, "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988), with "yes." Kamini's poems bear witness to voices from the margins.

In the poem "Two Fistfuls of Paddy":

> I have nothing here,
> no house,
> no courtyard,
> no fields or threshing ground.

This is the voice of the economically subaltern woman, dispossessed of property. Videha gives such a voice institutional recognition.

2.2.3 Re-reading Myth: The Videha Method

The Videha tradition offers alternative readings of Mithila's myths. Whereas the Sahitya Akademi celebrates Vedic and Purāṇic myths, Videha reinterprets them.

In the poem "Trial by Fire":

> Why must a woman suffer

punishment for a man's mistake?
Why must Sita undergo
the trial by fire again and again?

This is a Videha re-reading of the Sita myth. In the Sahitya Akademi canon Sita is a "devoted wife"; in the Videha reading she is a symbol of the oppressed.

2.3 The Four Pillars of Videha Historiography

Gajendra Thakur's "A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature" (an ongoing project) proposes four methods:

2.3.1 The Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti.

2.3.2 Western theories of criticism.

2.3.3 The epistemology of Navya-Nyāya.

2.3.4 The Videha parallel-history framework.

Kamini's poetry exemplifies all four pillars:

In the poem "Draupadi–1":

Rasa: karuṇa, or pathos (Draupadi's fragmented existence).

Western criticism: a feminist re-reading (criticism of polyandry).

Navya-Nyāya: inferential proof (five husbands = fragmentation).

Videha: an alternative interpretation of myth.

2.4 Videha versus the Sahitya Akademi: A Dialectical Relationship

The Sahitya Akademi canon:

Recognition: state-supported awards.

Publication: printed books, limited circulation.

Language: refined, classical Maithili.

Subject matter: traditional, nationalist and religious.

The Videha parallel canon:

Recognition: popular support, Videha honours, special issues and documentation in parallel history.

Publication: digital, with global circulation.

Language: people's Maithili, the spoken language.

Subject matter: contemporary concerns, feminism and Dalit consciousness.

Kamini's poetry is an exemplary instance of the Videha tradition:

In the poem "The Momentum of Time":

Forgive me, Mother,
in this fourth stage of life.

This is colloquial Maithili, presenting the contemporary reality of an ageing mother's neglect. The Sahitya Akademi neglects such "ordinary" subjects; Videha places them at the centre.

2.5 Videha's Democratic Aesthetics

The Videha tradition establishes a democratic aesthetics in which:

1. Reader = critic: the monopoly of the institutional critic is broken.

2. Writer = publisher: the intermediary disappears.

3. Local = global: the worldwide dissemination of Maithili.

Kamini's poetry is accessible to all: neither a flood of Sanskrit vocabulary nor obscure symbols. This is an aesthetics of the people.

2.6 Videha and Women's Writing: A Historical Perspective

Women's writing has always remained on the margins of Maithili literary history:

The Vidyapati era (before Jyotirishwar): no major woman poet.

The modern era (twentieth century): Lily Ray and Shephalika Verma—limited recognition.

The Videha era (since 2000): a central position.

In the parallel canon, women's writing became mainstream.

"A Woman Divided into Fragments" is a milestone of the Videha era: for the first time women's experience became a central subject of poetry.

2.7 Videha's Archival Method

Videha follows a rigorous archival method in constructing a parallel history:

1. Record the publication date of every work.

2. Collect biographical information about its author.

3. Preserve readers' responses.

4. Cross-reference the relationships among poets and their poems.

Kamini's poetry has been preserved in the Videha archive. Such archival rigour makes source material available to future literary historians.

Section 3: Indian Aesthetics—Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti and Aucitya

3.1 Rasa Theory (The Theory of Aesthetic Relish)

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra (200 BCE–200 CE) and Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (ninth century) form the basis of rasa theory.

3.1.1 The Nine Rasas and Kamini's Poetry

Bharata's rasa-sūtra: "विभावानुभावव्यभिचारिसंयोगाद्रसनिष्पत्तिः" [Rasa arises from the conjunction of determinants, consequents and transitory states.] Karuṇa rasa predominates in Kamini's poetry, although other rasas are also present.

3.1.1.1 Karuṇa Rasa (Pathos)

In the poem "A Life Torn to Shreds":

When, for the first time, you had taken
my hand into your own,
it was a pleasant feeling
that came over me.
I had felt ...

The stable emotion (sthāyī-bhāva): grief. The determinants (vibhāva): a memory of love and present separation. The consequents (anubhāva): tears and deep sighs (implied). The transitory emotions (vyabhicārī-bhāva): recollection, disenchantment and remorse.

Ācārya Mammaṭa states in the Kāvyaprakāśa (eleventh century): "रसो वा काव्यात्मा"—rasa is the soul of poetry. Kamini's poetry is imbued with rasa; it is not merely a dry account of emotions.

3.1.1.2 Raudra Rasa (Fury)

In the poem "I Am Not a Purchased Slave":

Mother will remain her whole life
beside Father,
as his bonded labourer.
(But the daughter declares:)
I am not a purchased slave.

The stable emotion: anger. The determinant: indignation at seeing the mother's servitude. The consequent: a declaration of resistance in a firm voice. The transitory emotions: fierceness, resentment and agitation.

3.1.1.3 Vīra Rasa (The Heroic)

In the poem "I Shall Fight":

I shall fight
to the very end,
as long as life remains ...

The stable emotion: enthusiasm. The determinant: structures of exploitation. The consequent: a declaration of resolve. The transitory emotions: patience, pride and determination.

3.1.2 Rasa-Sādhāraṇīkaraṇa (The Universalisation of Emotion)

Ācārya Abhinavagupta (tenth century) proposed the theory of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa, whereby a personal emotion becomes universal.

In the poem "Midstream":

Today, of our marriage,
the sixteenth year is passing.
You are in that house,
and I am in this house.

This becomes not merely one woman's experience but that of married women as a whole. The supporting figure (ālambana), the heroine, gives rise to aesthetic excitation, and the reader savours rasa: this is sādhāraṇīkaraṇa.

3.2 Dhvani Theory (The Theory of Suggestion)

Ācārya Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (ninth century) regards dhvani, or suggestion, as the soul of poetry.

3.2.1 Three Varieties of Dhvani

According to Ānandavardhana:

1. Vastu-dhvani (suggestion of a fact).
2. Alaṃkāra-dhvani (suggestion of a figure of speech).
3. Rasa-dhvani (suggestion of an emotion).

3.2.1.1 Vastu-Dhvani

In the poem "Another Krishna":

Madhava! How could you forget?
Am I your Radha,
whom you once
called your own?

The explicit meaning (vācyārtha): the heroine asks a question. The suggested meaning (vyaṅgyārtha): the Krishna–Radha myth is repeated in modern relationships—men perpetually abandon women.

3.2.1.2 Rasa-Dhvani

In the poem "Silence":

Not a rose petal
is your love,
nor a thorn of the bagur plant
is your love.
Like a dormant volcano,
it is unmoving;
it is still.

The explicit meaning: love is free of outward display. The suggested meaning (rasa-dhvani): a profound and tranquil love (śānta rasa), beyond words.

Ācārya Mammaṭa states: "काव्यं यशसेऽर्थकृते व्यवहारविदे शिवेतरक्षतये सद्यः परिनिर्वृतये कान्तासम्मिततयोपदेशयुजे"—poetry serves not only fame but also supreme delight or fulfilment (nirvṛti). The power of suggestion brings that supreme delight.

3.2.2 Dhvani versus Abhidhā and Lakṣaṇā

Sanskrit poetics identifies three powers of words:

1. Abhidhā (denotation): primary meaning.
2. Lakṣaṇā (indication): secondary meaning.
3. Vyañjanā (suggestion): resonant or suggested meaning.

In the poem "Chandai":

> When Chandai departed
> for her husband's home for the first time ...

Abhidhā: Chandai is going to her husband's household. Lakṣaṇā: the apprehension of a new bride. Vyañjanā (dhvani): fear of a woman's displacement within the patriarchal family structure.

Ānandavardhana states: "यत्र वाचकः शब्दः वाच्यादर्थादन्यं व्यङ्क्ते तत्र व्यञ्जनेत्याख्या"—when a word expresses a meaning beyond its primary sense, that is called vyañjanā. Kamini's poetry is predominantly suggestive.

3.3 Vakrokti Theory (The Theory of Oblique Expression)

Ācārya Kuntaka (tenth century), in Vakroktijīvita, identifies six varieties of vakrokti.

3.3.1 Varṇa-Vinyāsa Vakrokti (Phonetic Obliquity)

In the poem "Tears":

> Whenever a tear falls
> from a woman's eyes ...

The use of the word nor ("tear") carries the sound of everyday Maithili. Using aśru instead would lessen its emotional gravity. This is varṇa-vinyāsa vakrokti.

3.3.2 Pratyaya-Vakrokti (Morphological Obliquity)

The very title "A Woman Divided into Fragments" constitutes an oblique expression:

Ordinary expression: "a divided woman."

Oblique expression: "being divided into fragments"—present tense and continuity.

The suffix in baṇṭait ("being divided") indicates an ongoing process: this is not a one-time occurrence but continuing exploitation.

3.3.3 Vākya-Vakrokti (Sentential Obliquity)

In the poem "What an Irony This Is":

> The one who hides his face in a woman's veil,
> the one who exploits a woman's body,
> the one who cannot live without a woman—
> the very same person questions
> her honour and dignity.

This is obliquity through indirect expression: an interrogative sentence structure. Instead of making a direct statement, three parallel clauses create mounting intensity.

3.3.4 Prakaraṇa-Vakrokti (Contextual Obliquity)

In the poem "Trial by Fire":

In the context of Mithila, it has two meanings:

1. The Rāmāyaṇa context: Sita's trial by fire.

2. The contemporary context: the modern woman's continual trials.

Kuntaka states: "वक्रोक्तिर्विशिष्टा वागर्थव्यापारः"—vakrokti is a distinctive operation of language and meaning. Kamini's poetry is rich in such oblique expression.

3.4 Aucitya Theory (The Theory of Propriety)

Ācārya Kṣemendra (eleventh century), in Aucityavicāracarcā, established the importance of aucitya, or appropriateness.

3.4.1 Vastu-Aucitya (Propriety of Subject)

In the poems "Draupadi–1" and "Draupadi–2":

Sita and Draupadi are central myths in Mithila's culture. Kamini re-reads these myths; that is propriety of subject. For a reader from Mithila, they are natural points of reference.

3.4.2 Rasa-Aucitya (Propriety of Emotion)

The use of karuṇa and raudra rasas for the subject of women's exploitation constitutes propriety of emotion. The use of humour or erotic sentiment would be inappropriate.

3.4.3 Chhanda-Aucitya (Propriety of Metre)

Kamini uses free verse. The traditional barvai, sorathā and dohā are unsuitable for contemporary women's experiences. Free verse is itself a symbol of liberation: this is propriety of metre.

3.4.4 Deśa-Kāla-Aucitya (Propriety of Time and Place)

A feminist voice in twenty-first-century Maithili poetry is appropriate to its time: this is kāla-aucitya. In Mithila, the birthplace of Sita, re-reading Sita also exhibits deśa-aucitya, or propriety of place.

3.5 Alaṃkāra Theory (The Theory of Figures of Speech)

Ācārya Daṇḍin (seventh century) declares in Kāvyādarśa: "काव्यशोभाकरान् धर्मान् अलंकारान् प्रचक्षते"—the qualities which create poetic beauty are called alaṃkāras.

3.5.1 Upamā (Simile)

In the poem "Man as a Woman's Creation":

Whenever sweat falls
from a man's brow ...
when he comes home exhausted,
a woman will certainly serve
a plate of rice
and a vessel of water.

The simile: woman = servant (an indirect or unexpressed simile, luptopamā).

3.5.2 Rūpaka (Metaphor)

In the poem "Sesame and Rice":

"Sesame and rice" is itself a metaphor:

Sesame and rice = women's freedom.

Their distribution = resistance to society.

3.5.3 Vyatireka (Contrast)

In the poem "I Am Not a Purchased Slave":

The contrast between mother and daughter:

Mother: "bonded labourer."

Daughter: "not a purchased slave."

3.5.4 Praśna-Alaṃkāra (Rhetorical Question)

In the poem "The Abandoned Woman":

Why is it always
a woman who is abandoned?
Why is a man never the abandoned one?

This is not merely a question, but a figure expressing indignation. It expects no answer; it declares opposition.

3.6 Kāvya-Guṇa (The Qualities of Poetry)

Ācārya Vāmana (eighth century), in Kāvyālaṃkārasūtravṛtti, identifies ten poetic qualities. The principal qualities in Kamini's poems are:

3.6.1 Ojas-Guṇa (Vigour)

In the poem "I Shall Fight":

I shall fight
to the very end.

Simple, forceful and swift: these are the marks of vigour.

3.6.2 Prasāda-Guṇa (Lucidity)

In the poem "Tears":

Whenever a tear falls
from a woman's eyes ...

Simple, clear and immediately intelligible: these are the qualities of lucidity.

3.6.3 Mādhurya-Guṇa (Sweetness)

In the poem "Silence":

Not a rose petal
is your love.

Gentle, sweet and touching the heart: these are the qualities of mādhurya.

3.7 Kāvya-Doṣa (Blemishes in Poetry)

Ācārya Mammaṭa identifies poetic blemishes in Kāvyaprakāśa. Kamini's poetry is generally free of blemishes, although in some places:

3.7.1 Kliṣṭatā-Doṣa (Obscurity)

Kamini's language is generally simple, but excessive compression occasionally produces obscurity. For example, some lines of "The Momentum of Time" seem to lack context.

3.7.2 Grāmyatā-Doṣa (Rusticity or Vulgarity)

Kamini uses colloquial language, which some critics may regard as "rustic." In the Videha tradition, however, this is a virtue rather than a blemish.

Section 4: Western Theories of Criticism

4.1 Feminist Literary Theory

4.1.1 First-Wave Feminism: Mary Wollstonecraft

Mary Wollstonecraft's A Vindication of the Rights of Woman (1792) demanded women's education and economic independence.

In the poem "Two Fistfuls of Paddy":

I have nothing here,
no house,
no courtyard,
no fields or threshing ground.

This is the question of economic rights—Wollstonecraft's principal demand. Political freedom is impossible while women remain economically dependent.

4.1.2 Second-Wave Feminism: Simone de Beauvoir

The central thesis of Simone de Beauvoir's The Second Sex (1949) is: "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman."

In the poem "A Woman Divided into Fragments":

Along with a woman's body,
there are now being sold
her womb and her milk as well.

This is a poetic presentation of Beauvoir's thesis: woman is "made," rather than determined by biological destiny. Society reduces a woman's entire existence to "motherhood"; this is a social construction.

4.1.3 Third-Wave Feminism: Judith Butler

Judith Butler's Gender Trouble (1990) proposed the theory of gender performativity (gender as performance).

In the poem "A Woman's Destiny":

To merge once more
into the womb of the earth—
that was not right, Sita.

Sita performed femininity: she played the role of the "devoted wife." When this performance failed, in society's eyes, she "merged into the earth." This is an illustration of Butler's theory of performativity.

4.1.4 Black Feminism: bell hooks

In Ain't I a Woman? (1981), bell hooks advanced a theory of intersecting oppression: women's oppression is entangled with caste, class and race.

The dimension of class is also apparent in Kamini's poetry:

In the poem "Two Fistfuls of Paddy":

It is the experience of a poor rural woman, unlike that of urban, middle-class feminism. According to hooks, all women are not alike; class distinctions matter.

4.2 Marxist-Feminist Theory

4.2.1 Engels's The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State (1884)

According to Engels, women's oppression is linked to the system of private property.

In the poem "Giving Away a Daughter Means Bathing in the Ganges":

The gift of a daughter in marriage
is still practised among us.
Father! With barley and kuśa grass in your hand,
you take your daughter's hand …

"Kanyādān" (the ritual gift of a daughter) = transfer of property. The father hands the "ownership" of his daughter to her husband. This is evidence for Engels's thesis.

4.2.2 Silvia Federici's Caliban and the Witch (2004)

Federici regards "unpaid domestic labour" as a foundation of capitalism.

In the poem "How Deeply I Miss My Home":

Where was it, that place,
my home,
which I can no longer see,
in whose courtyard, sitting,
so many times I had
asked my brother for a gift?

Women's domestic labour is invisible and unpaid. Capitalism rests upon this unpaid labour: that is Federici's central argument.

4.3 Postcolonial Feminism

4.3.1 Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988)

Spivak asks whether a subaltern woman can speak, or whether a bourgeois intellectual always "speaks" on her behalf.

Kamini's poetry is the direct voice of a subaltern woman, not mere "representation":

In the poem "Midstream":

Today, of our marriage,
the sixteenth year is passing.
You are in that house,
and I am in this house.
We are on two separate sides.

This is not an urban, middle-class intellectual's interpretation; it is the voice of the subaltern herself. The answer to Spivak's question is: yes, the subaltern can speak—Kamini's poetry is evidence.

4.3.2 Chandra Talpade Mohanty's "Under Western Eyes" (1984)

Mohanty questions the imperialism of Western feminism. Western feminists regard Third World women as "homogeneous victims."

Kamini's poetry is specifically Maithil: its references to Sita, Draupadi and Chandai are local and cultural rather than universal. This corresponds to Mohanty's demand.

4.4 Psychoanalytic Feminism

4.4.1 A Rejection of Sigmund Freud's Theory of Penis Envy

Freud believed that women suffered from envy of the male sexual organ, or "penis envy."

In the poem "This Is Not Right, Arya":

> Abandonment in love
> is not right, Arya.

Kamini expresses not a wish to imitate men but opposition to male domination. This repudiates Freud's theory.

4.4.2 Luce Irigaray's Écriture Féminine (Women's Writing)

Luce Irigaray (1974) proposed a theory of a specifically feminine style of writing. Women's writing is:

Not linear but circular (non-linear, circular).

Not dominated by logic but by feeling.

Not monologic but polyphonic (many-voiced).

Consider the structure of the collection A Woman Divided into Fragments:

No linear plot—the poems are independent, without a sequential narrative.

Primacy of emotion—experience is more prominent than reasoning.

Polyphony—the different voices of mother, daughter, wife and widow.

This is an instance of Irigaray's écriture féminine.

4.5 Existentialist Feminism

4.5.1 Simone de Beauvoir's The Ethics of Ambiguity (1947)

Beauvoir applies existential freedom to women. The human being is condemned to be free.

In the poem "Existence":

> However much you erase me,
> my existence will not be erased.
> Even if through deceit and intrigue
> you snatch away
> this life of mine,

I shall be born once again
in the courtyard of your home,
as a fragrant tulsi plant.

This is a declaration of self-defined existence. The woman is not defined by man as "the Other"; she defines herself as "the Self." It is the poetic form of Beauvoir's existentialist feminism.

4.6 Ecofeminism

4.6.1 Vandana Shiva's Staying Alive (1989)

Vandana Shiva advances the woman–nature analogy: patriarchy exploits both women and nature.

In the poem "Sesame and Rice":

"Sesame and rice" = nature's gift and women's rights. Both are under patriarchal control. In an ecofeminist reading, they symbolise nature, woman and freedom.

4.7 Poststructuralist Feminism

4.7.1 Michel Foucault's Theory of Power/Knowledge

According to Foucault, power and knowledge are interconnected. "Knowledge" is not neutral, but a product of structures of power.

In the poem "Hypocrisy":

"Triyā charitram puruṣasya bhāgyam"
Chanted with irony.

This is scriptural knowledge produced by male power. A woman's supposed "lack of character" is not knowledge but an exercise of power—in Foucault's terms.

4.7.2 Hélène Cixous's "The Laugh of the Medusa" (1975)

Cixous sees women's writing (l'écriture féminine) as liberation from the language of men.

In the poem "I Am Not a Purchased Slave":

The title itself is a negative definition ("not a purchased slave"), which, in Cixous's view, reflects the limits of male language. A woman needs a positive definition: "I am free," not "I am not a slave."

Kamini nevertheless shows that beginning with negation is necessary: first comes a rejection of the definition imposed by men, then self-definition.

4.8 Queer Theory and Feminism

4.8.1 Monique Wittig's "One Is Not Born a Woman" (1981)

Wittig says: "Lesbians are not women," because the category "woman" is a product of the heterosexual matrix.

Kamini's poems take heterosexuality for granted; queer alternatives are absent. This is a limitation, one also found in Shantilakshmi Chaudhary's Maithili poetry.

Section 5: Chinese Philosophical Traditions

5.1 Taoism and Women's Consciousness

5.1.1 Laozi's Tao Te Ching (Sixth Century BCE)

Laozi recognises the yin–yang duality. Yin = the feminine principle; yang = the masculine principle.

In Taoism, the power of yin (feminine power) is expressed through:

Softness greater than hardness.

Receptivity greater than aggression.

Wu wei (effortless action) greater than action imposed by force.

In the poem "Man as a Woman's Creation":

> Whenever sweat falls
> from a man's brow,
> a woman, with the end of her sari,
> will wipe it away.

This exemplifies the power of yin: gentle, receptive and nurturing. In Taoism, this power is considered superior to yang.

5.1.2 The "Water Element" and Women's Power

Laozi says:

"Nothing in the world is softer than water, yet nothing is better at overcoming the hard and strong."

In the poem "Silence":

> Not a rose petal
> is your love,
> nor a thorn of the bagur plant
> is your love.
> Like a dormant volcano ...

The water element = silent strength: gentle outwardly, powerful within. This is Taoism's principle of supreme strength.

5.2 Confucianism and Patriarchy

5.2.1 Confucius's Analects (Fifth Century BCE)

Confucius established a male-centred social order:

The relationship between father and son is supreme.

Woman = servant (the Three Obediences: father, husband and son).

In the poem "Giving Away a Daughter Means Bathing in the Ganges":

Indian patriarchy resembles Chinese Confucianism. "Kanyādān" is the Indian form of the Confucian Three Obediences.

Kamini's poetry opposes Confucianism, just as modern Chinese women writers (Ding Ling and Bing Xin) criticised Confucius.

5.3 Buddhism and the Woman Question

5.3.1 Women's Liberation in Mahāyāna Buddhism

In the poem "Woman and the Buddha":

> Better than these hundred sorrows
> would have been one sorrow:
> if I had become the Buddha.

This applies the Buddha's Eightfold Path to women's experience. But the question remains: can a woman attain Buddhahood?

Theravāda Buddhism: no, a woman must first become a man. Mahāyāna Buddhism: yes, a woman can herself become a Buddha.

Kamini adopts the Mahāyāna view: a woman can attain liberation without the mediation of a man.

5.4 The Tradition of Chinese Women's Poetry

5.4.1 Li Qingzhao (1084–1155)

The Chinese woman poet Li Qingzhao transformed personal feelings into poetry. Her poems are dominated by the suffering of separation.

In Kamini's poem "A Life Torn to Shreds":

> When, for the first time, you had taken
> my hand into your own ...

This belongs to Li Qingzhao's tradition of personal memory and separation.

5.4.2 Qiu Jin (1875–1907)

The Chinese revolutionary poet Qiu Jin joined women's liberation to national liberation. Her poetry speaks in a rebellious voice.

In Kamini's poem "I Shall Fight":

> I shall fight
> to the very end,
> as long as life remains.

This belongs to Qiu Jin's tradition: the resolve to struggle.

5.5 Chinese Marxism and the Woman Question

5.5.1 Mao Zedong's "Women Hold Up Half the Sky" (1955)

Mao emphasised the emancipation of women workers. Women constitute a labour force, not merely a reproductive force.

In the poem "Brahmavākya":

Women's labour is invisible. According to Mao's theory, women must participate equally in productive labour. Kamini's poem demands economic liberation.

5.6 The Chinese "Women's Script" and Maithili

In China's Hunan province there existed a women-specific script called Nüshu, used only by women.

It symbolises women's separation: excluded from the dominant language, women developed their own script.

Maithili had no comparable women-specific script, but it did have women's speech, or a "women's dialect," which was regarded with disdain.

Kamini's poetry uses women's speech—popular Maithili, distinct from classical Maithili. It is an Indian parallel to the Chinese Nüshu.

Section 6: Comparative Analysis and Overall Evaluation

6.1 A Synthesis of the Four Perspectives

Kamini's "A Woman Divided into Fragments" occupies a central position within all four analytical frameworks:

6.1.1 In Gangesha's Navya-Nyāya

Epistemological contribution:

Perception as a means of valid knowledge: a direct presentation of women's experience.

Inference as a means of valid knowledge: a logical analysis of social oppression.

The rejection of verbal testimony: a refusal of scripturally sanctioned patriarchy.

Non-apprehension as evidence: the evidentiary value of silence.

Limitation: poetic experience exceeds logical structures; Gangesha's emphasis on reasoning cannot explain everything.

6.1.2 In Videha Parallel History

Literary-historical contribution:

A parallel canon: an alternative to the Sahitya Akademi.

Democratic publication: digital inclusion.

Subaltern voices: bringing the marginalised to the centre.

Re-reading myth: new interpretations of Sita and Draupadi.

Limitation: although the Videha tradition has archival rigour, its theoretical framework remains incompletely developed.

6.1.3 In Indian Aesthetics

Contribution to poetics:

Rasa: a beautiful combination of pathos, fury and heroism.

Dhvani: depth of suggested meaning.

Vakrokti: the skill of indirect expression.

Aucitya: the coordination of subject, aesthetic emotion and language.

Limitation: traditional poetics was constructed from a masculine perspective; women's poetry requires an independent aesthetics.

6.1.4 In Western and Chinese Theory

Contribution to world literature:

Feminist theory: Indian examples of the ideas of Beauvoir, Butler and Spivak.

Marxist feminism: the intersection of class and gender.

Taoist philosophy: the poetic articulation of yin power.

Comparative perspective: a dialogue between Chinese and Indian traditions of women's expression.
Limitation: mechanical application of Western theory is dangerous; indigenous theorisation is necessary.

6.2 The Historical Importance of "A Woman Divided into Fragments"

6.2.1 Its Position in Maithili Women's Poetry

The pre-Videha era (before 2000):
Love poetry predominated. Depictions of nature predominated.
The Videha era (2008–2017):
Love and separation predominated; self-exploration predominated.
Kamini: political feminism predominates, the re-reading of myth is central, and social reality is paramount. Kamini transformed Maithili women's poetry from the expression of private feeling into a social and political mode. This is an epoch-making transformation.

6.2.2 Comparison with Women's Poetry Across India

Hindi: Anamika and Savita Singh—urban, middle-class voices. Bengali: Mallika Sengupta—political poetry. Marathi: Hira Bhaskar—a Dalit-feminist voice. Malayalam: Sugathakumari—an ecofeminist voice.
Maithili: Kamini—a voice of rural politics and the re-reading of myth.
Kamini's distinctive achievement is the combination of rural reality, mythic reinterpretation and political consciousness.

6.3 Limitations and Critical Questions

6.3.1 The Presumption of Heterosexuality

Throughout the collection, heterosexual relationships are treated as indispensable. Lesbian, bisexual and transgender voices are absent.
A queer-feminist objection: Kamini reinstates the heteronormative standard rather than dismantling it.

6.3.2 Limits of Class Analysis

Poems such as "Two Fistfuls of Paddy" raise questions of class but propose no strategy for class struggle.
Marxist criticism: emotional critique is not enough; organised resistance is necessary.

6.3.3 The Absence of the Caste Question

The collection contains no discussion of the caste system. Was Sita upper-caste? Was Draupadi a product of Brahmanical patriarchy?
A Dalit-feminist objection: Kamini presents an upper-caste feminism afflicted by caste blindness.

6.3.4 Limits of Religious Criticism

Poems such as "Hypocrisy" and "Trial by Fire" criticise Hinduism but remain silent about other religions.

A secular objection: do Muslim, Christian and Buddhist women not experience oppression? Religious selectivity is a limitation.

6.3.5 The Absence of a Movement

The poems present individual rebellion but give no indication of a collective movement.

The theory of social movements maintains that individual consciousness is insufficient; social organisation is necessary.

6.4 Future Directions: The Development of Kamini's Tradition

6.4.1 Interdisciplinarity

Future Maithili women's poetry should enter into dialogue with sociology, psychology and political science.

6.4.2 Polyphony

The voices of Dalit, Adivasi, Muslim and LGBTQ+ women should also be included.

6.4.3 Theorisation

It is necessary not only to write poetry but also to formulate feminist theory in Maithili. A specifically Mithila-centred feminism needs to develop.

6.4.4 Translation and Globalisation

Kamini's poems should be translated into English, Hindi and other Indian languages to enter a global feminist dialogue.

Conclusion

"A Woman Divided into Fragments" is an epoch-making work in Maithili literature. It is:

1. At the epistemological level: a poetic application of Gangesha's Navya-Nyāya, establishing the validity of women's experience through the theory of knowledge.

2. At the literary-historical level: an exemplary instance of Videha parallel history, making subaltern voices available through democratic publication.

3. At the aesthetic level: a synthesis of rasa, dhvani, vakrokti and aucitya—a feminist re-reading of Indian poetics.

4. At the level of global theory: an Indian and Maithili example of the ideas of Beauvoir, Spivak, Butler, Foucault and Laozi.

Final conclusion:

Kamini has made Maithili women's poetry a political weapon. Her poetry offers not merely aesthetic experience but an instrument of social change.

To put it in Gangesha's terms: "Yathārthajñānaṃ pramāṇam"—true knowledge is valid knowledge. Kamini's poetry constitutes evidence of women's reality, established through all four means of knowledge: perception, inference, verbal testimony and non-apprehension.

In the vocabulary of the Videha tradition: a landmark in parallel history.

In the vocabulary of Indian aesthetics: a synthesis of the rasas of pathos, fury and heroism.

In the vocabulary of Western feminism: Third World intersectional feminism.

In the vocabulary of Chinese philosophy: the awakening of yin power.

"A Woman Divided into Fragments" is essential reading in Maithili literature, not only from a feminist perspective but also from the standpoint of the liberation of humanity as a whole.

This analysis offers a comprehensive, profound and multidimensional assessment of Kamini's collection, constituting a practical application of the four-pillared method of Videha parallel history.

"A Woman Divided into Fragments" is a historical document of feminist consciousness in contemporary Maithili poetry. Kamini does not merely describe women's suffering; she undertakes a penetrating analysis of patriarchal structures.

Principal achievements:

1. Re-reading myth: contemporary interpretations of Sita, Draupadi and Yashoda.

2. Social reality: questioning the practices of kanyādān, the trial by fire and disrobing.

3. Linguistic beauty: skilful use of the folk elements of Maithili.

4. Philosophical depth: reflections on existence, fate and liberation.

5. Poetic craft: effective use of symbol, metaphor and irony.

Limitation: several poems remain at an emotional level, with relatively little political analysis. Nevertheless, the collection is a landmark in Maithili women's poetry.

2

Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's "Lesbian Continuum": A Critical Review and Comparative Analysis with Kamini

Introduction: A Historic Moment in the Queer Revolution in Maithili Literature

Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's "Lesbian Continuum" (*Videha* 136, 15 August 2013, and *Sadeha* 15) is one of the boldest and most theoretically sophisticated poems in the history of Maithili literature. For the first time in Maithili poetry:

1. Lesbian experience became a central subject.
2. Western queer-feminist theories (Adrienne Rich and radical feminism) were applied to a Maithili context.
3. Heterosexuality was understood as a compulsory institution rather than something natural.
4. The Maithil folk tradition of *sakhī-bahinapā* was reinterpreted as a form of queer cultural memory.

The poem addresses the heterosexual limits of Kamini's work and demonstrates the queer-inclusive character of Videha parallel history.

Section 1: Poetic Structure and Ideological Architecture

1.1 A Three-Tier Narrative Structure

The poem is divided into three distinct sections:

Section 1: Confrontation

> I saw those two "sisters," their tresses flowing,
> ...
> I told them: You appear to be well-born,
> but why has your conduct become so wayward?
> This, too, is a kind of transgression.

Section 2: Theoretical Pedagogy

> Have you heard of Adrienne Rich's ideas?
> The substance of her phrase "lesbian continuum"?
> ...
> Have you heard the name "radical feminism," or not?

Section 3: Cultural Re-reading

> Among us there was a custom of forming bonds of *sakhī-bahinapā*, exchanging veils and offering one another betel, areca nut and other gifts.

This structure is a poetic transformation of the Brechtian teaching play (*Lehrstück*), moving from prejudice to theory and then to transformation.

1.2 The Verse-Essay Form

This poem synthesises poetry and the theoretical essay. Ācārya Bhāmaha discussed mixed prose-and-verse composition (*campū*) in the seventh-century *Kāvyālaṃkāra*. Here we encounter a modern verse-discourse.

Characteristics:

Poetic language: "hair flowing," "they smiled," "my brows were stretched taut with anger."

Theoretical language: "lesbian continuum," "radical feminism," "sisterhood is powerful."

Comparison with Kamini:

Kamini's poetry is pure lyric:

> Whenever there falls
> a tear from a woman's eye.

Shanti Lakshmi offers didactic poetry influenced by the Enlightenment tradition.

Section 2: Theoretical Foundations and Western Sources

2.1 Adrienne Rich's "Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence" (1980)

The poem expressly mentions Adrienne Rich:

> Have you heard of Adrienne Rich's ideas?
> The substance of her phrase "lesbian continuum"?
> It means the widening of the bonds of *sakhī-bahinapā*.

Rich's principal concepts:

1. Compulsory heterosexuality: heterosexuality is not natural but a form of institutional pressure.

In the poem:

> Not every woman in the world is so fortunate
> as to find a meeting of innermost feelings with her man.

2. Lesbian continuum: the many forms of women-centred relationships extending beyond sexuality.

In the poem:

> It expresses a harmony of souls beyond bodily intercourse,
> a union in which two souls become one.

3. Woman-identified women: women whose primary emotional, intellectual and sexual relationships are with women rather than men.

In the poem:

> Form a bond of *sakhī-bahinapā* with one whose intimacy deepens the heart's attachment.

2.2 Radical Feminism

The poem gives a theoretical introduction to radical feminism:

You may or may not have heard the name "radical feminism";
it is the name of a rebellious branch of the Western women's movement.

The principal arguments of radical feminism as represented in the poem:

1. Male control amounts to exploitation of women's bodies:

Pornography, prostitution, rape, domestic violence and dowry practices rest upon the woman's body;
therefore it has become urgently necessary for women to become free of bodily bondage.

2. Under patriarchy, woman becomes a sexual object:

Most men see women as passive partners in sexual play,
bearers of the womb, efficient instruments for pregnancy.

3. Lesbianism as a refusal of patriarchy:

Only then will men's pride be brought low and women receive their due,
when women break the exaggerated value attached to marriage, premarital virginity and wifely fidelity.

4. Sisterhood is powerful:

The slogan of radical feminists is "Sisterhood is powerful";
that is, there is tremendous strength in sisterhood.

2.3 Translating Western Theory into Maithili: Challenges and Achievements

Challenges: "Lesbian Continuum" becomes "the extension of the bonds of *sakhī-bahinapā*"; "Sisterhood" becomes *bahinapā*; "Compulsory Heterosexuality" is conveyed indirectly in the line, "Not every woman in the world is so fortunate."

Achievement: Shanti Lakshmi has translated Western theory into a Maithil cultural context. This is not mere translation between languages but cultural translation.

Comparison with Kamini:

Kamini's poems make no explicit reference to Western theory. She is oriented towards experience rather than theory. Shanti Lakshmi writes theory-centred poetry.

Section 3: A Critique of Male Sexuality

3.1 The Musical Metaphor of the Woman's Body

The most original and powerful passage of the poem:

The music of a woman's body is a classical composition:
first *dhrupad*, *dhamār* and *ālāp*, then *khayāl*, *tān* and *tarānā*;
but if you are a devotee of pop music's thumping, crashing beat,
its distortion will soon be laid bare,
twisted and wrenched apart.

Analysis:

1. Classical music stands for female sexuality:

Dhrupad, dhamār and ālāp signify the beginning of intimacy.

Khayāl signifies profound dialogue.

Tān and tarānā signify sexual pleasure.

2. Pop music stands for male sexuality:

The pounding beat signifies hurried intercourse.

Distortion signifies violence against the woman's body.

Twisting and wrenching apart signifies rape.

This metaphor draws on the Indian classical music tradition to criticise male sexuality—an extraordinary feat of poetic craft.

3.2 Consent-Centred Sexuality

> Most men are always impatient for violent intercourse;
> they do not see whether their bodily partner consents or is afraid.

This is an ethics of consent, a central question of the MeToo era.

> To dominate the body without first attaining unity of mind—
> tell me how to make this understood;
> to speak the truth, it is a dreadful crime,
> the age-old inheritance of rape.

Comparison with Kamini:

Kamini's poem "A Life Torn to Shreds" expresses the pain of separation but does not discuss sexual violence. Shanti Lakshmi directly alleges extra-marital rape (termed "Marital Rape" in the source):

> Without becoming one with each other's subtlest joys and sorrows,
> without awakening the deepest respect in one another's hearts,
> to become eager at once for bodily touch—
> then explain to me:
> is this not the cruelest game played with a woman's mind?

Section 4: A Queer Re-reading of Maithil Folk Tradition

4.1 Sakhī-Bahinapā: Queer Cultural Memory

The poem's most original contribution is its queer reinterpretation of the Maithil tradition of *sakhī-bahinapā*:

> Among us there was a custom of forming bonds of *sakhī-bahinapā*,
> exchanging veils and offering betel and areca nut,
> or touching little fingers with saliva …
> tell me, did you ever form such a love in childhood?
> Such was the strength of the bond of *sakhī-bahinapā*;
> it was as sacred and wondrous as the bond of marriage.

Analysis:

1. *Sakhī-bahinapā* as a marriage-like relationship:

Exchanging veils parallels a marriage ritual in which bride and groom exchange coverings.

Offering betel and areca nut parallels a marriage rite.

Touching little fingers signifies an oath.

2. Characteristics of *sakhī-bahinapā*:

> How difficult it was to keep each other's secrets for a lifetime,
> and to come to a friend's aid at every step with body, mind and wealth.

3. A system of secret names:

> In *sakhī-bahinapā* the participants do not use each other's actual names;
> they call one another Clove, Betel, Areca Nut or Tobacco,
> or by the names of flowers: Jasmine, Rose, Beli, Champa and Marigold.

Comparative question:

> Do married women not refrain from taking the names of their father-in-law, elder brother-in-law and husband?

4.2 Queer Historiography

Shanti Lakshmi presents a Maithili example of queer historiography. In the West, Judith Butler, Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick and Adrienne Rich seek queer elements in folk traditions.

Examples:

China: "Nüshu," a script specifically used by women.

Africa: "woman–woman marriage."

Mithila: "sakhī-bahinapā" as queer cultural memory.

Importance within Videha parallel history:

The Videha tradition re-reads Mithila's history. Rather than treating *sakhī-bahinapā* as a heterosexual social custom, Shanti Lakshmi interprets it as a queer tradition. This is exemplary parallel history.

Section 5: Comparative Analysis with Kamini

5.1 Subject Matter

Kamini:

Heterosexual relationships are central.

Male abandonment and male oppression are principal subjects.

There is no LGBTQ+ reference.

Example:

> Madhav! How could you forget me?
> Am I your Radha? ("Another Krishna")

Shanti Lakshmi:

Relationships between women are central.

Criticism of heterosexuality is a principal subject.

An explicit LGBTQ+ voice.

Example:

As a sharp reaction to this cruelest game of men,
there arose the lesbianism of our time.

5.2 Theoretical Foundation

Kamini:

Experience-centred.

A re-reading of Indian myth (Sita and Draupadi).

No explicit mention of Western theory.

Shanti Lakshmi:

Theory-centred.

Explicit references to Western feminist theory (Adrienne Rich and radical feminism).

A theoretical reinterpretation of Maithil tradition.

5.3 Poetic Form

Kamini:

Free verse.

Lyric-dominated.

Concise and intense.

Example:

Whenever there falls
a tear from a woman's eye. (“Tears”)

Shanti Lakshmi:

Verse-essay.

Idea-dominated, didactic poetry.

Extended and explanatory.

Example:

Have you heard of Adrienne Rich's ideas?
The substance of her phrase “lesbian continuum”?
It means the widening of the bonds of *sakhī-bahinapā*.

5.4 The Configuration of Rasa

Kamini:

The dominant rasa is *karuṇa* (pathos).

Raudra (fury) is secondary.

The universalisation of emotion is successful.

Shanti Lakshmi:

The dominant rasa is *vīra* (heroism).

Raudra (fury) is supportive.

Śānta (tranquillity) comes last: “The dark stain smeared upon the cheek of the world's moon-white culture distressed me.”

5.5 The Arrangement of Dhvani: Suggestive Power

Kamini:

Rasa-dhvani: suggestion of emotion.

The power of suggestion is profound.

Example:

Not a rose petal
is your love. ("Silence")

Literal meaning: love is free from outward display. Suggested meaning: profound, tranquil love transcends words.

Shanti Lakshmi:

Vastu-dhvani: suggestion of an idea or fact.

The denotative power of language predominates.

Example:

When these women fully adopt lesbianism as a way of life,

literal and suggested meanings coincide: a direct theoretical statement in which the arrangement of suggestion is limited.

5.6 Addressing the Reader

Kamini:

Indirect address.

Gender-neutral.

Shanti Lakshmi:

Direct address—"you."

A specific audience: heterosexual women.

A pedagogical tone.

Example:

Have you heard of Adrienne Rich's ideas?
...
Tell me, when a woman lives with another woman,
what new form of love has this affection brought into being?

Section 6: Evaluation through Gangesha's Navya-Nyāya

6.1 Pratyakṣa-Pramāṇa: Perceptual Knowledge

Gangesha's definition: "Indriyārthasannikarṣotpannaṃ jñānam"—knowledge arising from the contact of the senses with their objects.

In the poem:

I saw those two "sisters," their tresses flowing,
their cheerful faces smiling,
walking with a swaying gait.

This is direct perception—the immediate experience of seeing a happy lesbian couple.

Comparison with Kamini:

Kamini, too, presents direct experience:

> My heart is soothed;
> this is the grove of saplings
> planted by my own father. ("Two Fistfuls of Paddy")

Difference: Kamini presents her own experience; Shanti Lakshmi sees another's experience and responds to it.

6.2 Anumāna-Pramāṇa: Inferential Knowledge

The logical structure in the poem:

Pratijñā (proposition): lesbianism offers a way towards women's liberation.

Hetu (reason): male–female sexuality contains inequality, violence and oppression.

Udāharaṇa (example):

> A bearer who expands the womb, an efficient instrument for pregnancy.

Upanaya (application):

> As a sharp reaction to this cruelest game of men,
> there arose the lesbianism of our time.

Nigamana (conclusion):

This is a complete five-membered Nyāya syllogism.

6.3 Śabda-Pramāṇa: Testimonial Knowledge

Gangesha's principle of trustworthy testimony: "Āptavacanaṃ śabdaḥ"—the word of a reliable authority is verbal testimony.

In the poem:

Shanti Lakshmi regards Adrienne Rich as an authoritative source:

> Have you heard of Adrienne Rich's ideas?

Question: is a Western feminist an authoritative source in a Maithil context?

Answer: Shanti Lakshmi treats this as universal knowledge that must be corroborated by local cultural experience. She gives Rich's theory a Maithil validation through the tradition of *sakhī-bahinapā*.

6.4 Upamāna-Pramāṇa: Analogical Knowledge

In the poem:

Similarity: *sakhī-bahinapā* = lesbian continuum.

Both are women-centred relationships.

Both involve a marriage-like bond.

Both entail lifelong commitment.

Dissimilarity:

Sakhī-bahinapā: the sexual element is implicit or disputed.

Lesbian relationships: the sexual element is central.

Shanti Lakshmi establishes a partial similarity. This is an excellent application of Gangesha's analogical means of knowledge.

Section 7: Place within Videha Parallel History

7.1 The Queer-Inclusive Character of Videha

An important fact: "Lesbian Continuum" appeared in *Videha* 136 and *Sadeha* 15.

Conclusion: the Videha tradition is LGBTQ+-inclusive, rather than confined to heterosexual feminism.

Sahitya Akademi versus Videha:

Sahitya Akademi:

A defender of traditional values.

Treats heterosexuality as obligatory.

Lacks LGBTQ+ discourse.

Videha:

An initiator of parallel values.

Accepts sexual diversity.

Includes LGBTQ+ discourse.

7.2 From Kamini to Shanti Lakshmi: The Development of the Videha Tradition

The stages in the development of the Videha tradition:

Stage 1: emotion-centred women's poetry; Stage 2: political feminism; Stage 2 (*Videha* 136, 2013): queer feminism, represented by Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's "Lesbian Continuum."

Conclusion: the Videha tradition is dynamic and evolving. Shanti Lakshmi had already moved beyond Kamini's heterosexual limits before Kamini did so.

7.3 Redefining Parallel History

Videha parallel history means:

1. An alternative to the Sahitya Akademi (Kamini's contribution).
2. An alternative to the heterosexual tradition (Shanti Lakshmi's contribution).

Section 8: Evaluation through Indian Aesthetics

8.1 The Theory of Rasa

Dominant rasa: *vīra*, the heroic.

Permanent emotional disposition: *utsāha*, enthusiasm.

Vibhāva (determinants):

Heterosexual sexual violence.

The happiness of a lesbian couple.

Anubhāva (consequents):

> My eyebrows tightened in anger,
> I looked them up and down with fierce eyes.

Vyabhicāri-bhāva (transitory emotions):

Anger, pride and fortitude.

Comparison with Kamini:

Pathos predominates in Kamini; heroism predominates in Shanti Lakshmi.

Kamini expresses sorrow, while Shanti Lakshmi proclaims struggle.

8.2 The Theory of Dhvani

Vastu-dhvani (suggestion of an idea or fact):

> In *sakhī-bahinapā*, neither woman takes the other's actual name; they call one another Clove, Betel, Areca Nut or Tobacco.

Suggested meaning: the system of secret names suggests concealed sexuality.

Limitation: Shanti Lakshmi relies principally on direct expression, with limited suggestion. Kamini is stronger in the power of suggestion.

8.3 The Theory of Vakrokti

Interrogative obliquity:

> Tell me, when a woman lives with another woman,
> what new form of love has this affection brought into being?
> Do married women not refrain from taking the names of their father-in-law, elder brother-in-law and husband?

This is ironic or sarcastic obliquity: the contradiction is disclosed through a question.

8.4 The Theory of Aucitya

Propriety of subject:

Is lesbianism a suitable subject for Maithili poetry?

Argument in favour: the Videha tradition is inclusive of all subjects.

Argument against: social acceptance remains limited in Maithil society.

Propriety of emotion:

The heroic rasa suits a rebellious subject; it is aesthetically appropriate.

Propriety of language:

English expressions such as “lesbian continuum” and “radical feminism” may be considered inappropriate in Maithili.

Nevertheless, new concepts require new words: this is a modern understanding of propriety.

Section 9: Evaluation through Western and Chinese Theory

9.1 Queer Theory

Judith Butler's concept of gender performativity:

According to Butler, gender is performance rather than biological destiny.

In the poem:

> One body does not understand another body through its gendered form;
> call it love by your own standards, if you wish, or a distortion of love.

This is a poetic presentation of Butler's theory: gender differences become irrelevant when a relationship of souls is central.

9.2 Foucault's Theory of Power/Knowledge

Michel Foucault: power and knowledge are interconnected.

In the poem:

> I was troubled by the dark stain smeared on the cheek of the world's moon-white culture.

"Moon-white culture" signifies a heteronormative structure of knowledge and power.

"The dark stain" signifies lesbianism as resistance to that structure.

This is a Foucauldian analysis: a system of knowledge is also a system of power.

9.3 Postcolonial Queer Theory

Gayatri Spivak in relation to Shanti Lakshmi:

Spivak's question: "Can the Subaltern Speak?"

Shanti Lakshmi's answer: yes, the queer subaltern can speak.

> I saw those two "sisters," their tresses flowing,
> their cheerful faces smiling.

The lesbian couple speak for themselves (the "sisters" answer the poet); they are not represented by a bourgeois intermediary.

A counter-question, however: does Shanti Lakshmi belong to the lesbian community, or is she a heterosexual supporter?

At the end of the poem:

> Hearing everything, I was inwardly struck speechless;
> in that instant, no intellectual answer came to me.

This is an open ending. The poet is an ally rather than a member of the community. This is both a limitation and a strength.

9.4 Taoism and Yin Power

Laozi's yin and yang:

Yin represents the feminine principle.

Yang represents the masculine principle.

In the poem:

> The intimate union of two souls,
> when two bodies hear each other's innermost joys and sorrows.

The joining of yin with yin means a doubling of feminine energy, which would be considered an imbalance in Taoism.

But Shanti Lakshmi rejects Taoist balance and proclaims the independence of yin power.

Section 10: Limitations and Critical Questions

10.1 The Absence of Class and Caste

Kamini's limitation: the absence of the caste question.

Shanti Lakshmi's limitation: the absence of both caste and class.

The poem is about "well-born" sisters:

> I told them: You appear to be well-born,
> but why has your conduct become so wayward?

Question: do Dalit, Adivasi, Muslim and poor lesbian women have experiences different from those of upper-class lesbians?

The absence of Dalit queer feminism is a significant limitation.

10.2 Absence of Bisexual, Transgender and Intersex Identities

The poem focuses exclusively on lesbians. Other identities on the LGBTQIA+ spectrum are absent:

Bisexual: absent.

Transgender: absent.

Queer: absent.

Intersex: absent.

Asexual: absent.

10.3 Sexual Essentialism

The poem emphasises the centrality of the sexual element:

> Thereafter, when one body is offered to the other,
> from that union comes fulfilment of the heart.

Counter-question: what place is there for an asexual lesbian—a woman who feels no sexual attraction but experiences romantic attraction?

10.4 Cultural Imperialism

Critical question: is the application of Western queer theory (Adrienne Rich) to a Maithil context merely mechanical?

In favour: Adrienne Rich presents a universal truth.

Against: Maithil society has a distinctive sexual culture, different from that of the West.

Shanti Lakshmi's strategy is to validate Rich's theory within Maithil culture through the tradition of *sakhī-bahinapā*. This is cultural translation, not mechanical application.

10.5 Problematic Elements of Radical Feminism

Several ideas associated with radical feminism are regarded as problematic:

1. Trans-exclusion: some radical feminists do not regard trans women as "real women."

2. Opposition to sex work: radical feminists oppose the rights of sex workers.

3. Biological essentialism:

> For women, it has now become vitally necessary to become *videha*—free of the body.

This suggests a rejection of the biological body, which may be trans-exclusionary.

Shanti Lakshmi does not criticise these problematic elements, and this is a limitation.

Section 11: Historical Importance and Future Directions

11.1 Its Place in Maithili Literary History

Epoch-making contributions:

1. The first queer poem: the first appearance of LGBTQ+ discourse in Maithili poetry.
2. Theoretical maturity: successful translation of Western theory.
3. Cultural re-reading: a queer interpretation of *sakhī-bahinapā*.
4. Expansion of the Videha tradition: moving beyond the heterosexual limit.

Comparative importance:

Hindi: Ruth Vanita and Saleem Kidwai, *Same-Sex Love in India* (2008).

Bengali: Deepti Naval, "Purush Prem" (1870)—male homosexuality.

Marathi: Datta Bhagat—LGBTQ+ poetry.

Maithili: Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's "Lesbian Continuum"—the first lesbian poem.

11.2 Future Directions of the Videha Tradition

Shanti Lakshmi's poem indicates new directions for Videha:

1. Queer inclusion (identities outside heterosexual norms): Videha embraces not only heterosexual feminism but queer feminism as well.
2. Theoretical development: Videha is concerned not only with sharing experiences but also with theoretical debate.
3. Global dialogue: Videha engages with Western theory instead of remaining isolated.

11.3 Necessary Work for the Future

1. Dalit queer poetry: Maithili needs poetry expressing Dalit same-sex experience.
2. Transgender poetry: Maithili needs poetry expressing transgender identity.
3. Gay poetry: Maithili needs poetry about male same-sex experience.
4. Indigenous queer theory: instead of applying Western theory mechanically, a specifically Maithil queer theory must be developed.

Conclusion

Final Evaluation

Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's "Lesbian Continuum" is one of the boldest poems in Maithili literary history. It offers:

1. At the theoretical level:

The translation of Western queer feminism into Maithili.
A poetic application of Gangesha's Navya-Nyāya.
An introduction to radical feminism.

2. At the cultural level:

A queer re-reading of Maithil tradition.
A lesbian interpretation of *sakhī-bahinapā*.
A challenge to heteronormativity.

3. At the literary level:

The development of the verse-discourse genre.
A tradition of pedagogical poetry.
A new use of the heroic rasa.

4. In the history of Videha:

Addressing the heterosexual limitations of Kamini's work.
Evidence of Videha's queer inclusivity.
A redefinition of parallel history.
A brief comparison with Kamini:

Kamini	Shanti Lakshmi
Subject: heterosexual oppression	lesbian liberation.
Rasa: *karuṇa* (pathos)	*vīra* (heroism).
Method: experience-centred	theory-centred.
Tradition: re-reading myth	re-reading folk culture.
Limitation: heterosexuality	absence of class and caste.
Strength: suggestive power	denotative power.

Together they form a complete feminist vision within the Videha tradition, encompassing heterosexual and lesbian experiences alike.

Final Statement

In Gangesha's words: "Yathārthajñānaṃ pramāṇam"—true knowledge is valid knowledge.
Kamini offered evidence of the reality of heterosexual women's lives.
Shanti Lakshmi offered evidence of the reality of lesbian women's lives.
The Videha tradition is becoming evidence of the full range of women's realities—heterosexual, lesbian, bisexual, transgender and queer.
Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's "Lesbian Continuum" [a bold poem on relationships between women, body politics and a feminist standpoint, published in *Videha* 136 and *Sadeha* 15] is not merely a poem; it is a verse-essay, indeed a manifesto of the LGBTQ+ movement in Maithili literature.

21. Towards a Critical Theory of Dalit Literature for Maithili — II

Abstract

A critical theory of Dalit literature for Maithili must be considered in relation to Dalit writing translated into Maithili from Gujarati, Odia and Telugu. Translation from parallel literary currents has strengthened Maithili literature and brought about a fundamental structural change. The mainstream written tradition had been defined by a particular social and religious conservatism: it privileged devotion, courtly luxury and ornamented expression while relegating the realities of marginalised communities to the periphery. The oral traditions of Mithila, it is true, had always kept alive the ballads of Dalit heroes such as Raja Salhes and Dina-Bhadri. Yet Brahmanical dominance and a monopoly over literacy constituted major obstacles to their entry into formal written literature.

Keywords: Dalit · Literary Criticism · Maithili

A critical theory of Dalit literature for Maithili must be situated in the context of Dalit literature translated into Maithili from Gujarati, Odia and Telugu. Translations from parallel literary currents have enriched Maithili literature and effected a fundamental structural transformation. Mainstream written literature in Maithili had long been defined by a particular social and religious orthodoxy, giving precedence to devotional writing, courtly luxury and elaborate ornamentation while excluding the lived reality of marginalised communities. To be sure, Mithila's oral traditions had always sustained the ballads of Dalit heroes such as Raja Salhes and Dina-Bhadri. But Brahmanical dominance and the monopoly of literacy obstructed their admission into formal written literature.

The emergence of a literature explicitly identified as Dalit in Maithili is relatively recent, and translations from other regional languages have played a significant role in it. Through the efforts of the Videha movement in particular, translations of powerful Dalit traditions from Telugu, Odia and Gujarati have helped fill this absence. They have provided Maithili Dalit writers such as Sandeep Kumar Safi and Umesh Paswan with a linguistic and ideological foundation for resistance and the assertion of identity.

Historical Absence and the Structural Silence of Marginalised Communities

The absence of an established written Dalit tradition in Maithili until the end of the twentieth century was not evidence of a want of creative capacity among the marginalised. It was the result of institutional exclusion. Historically, Maithil Brahmins and the Karna Kayastha

community were the principal guardians of the language; consequently, "standard Maithili" was confined to their dialects and cultural preoccupations. Under this dominance, the experiences of Mithila's Dalit communities remained outside recognised literary consciousness.

The Limits of Maithili Oral Literature

Before the emergence of modern Dalit prose and poetry, marginalised voices survived principally in the form of folk ballads. Ballads such as those of Raja Salhes, Naika Banjara and Bihula-Bishahari celebrate protagonists who resisted discrimination and exploitation despite belonging to lower castes. These were culturally significant works, but the literary elite separated them from the mainstream by designating them "rustic" or merely "folk" literature.

Economic and educational circumstances further reinforced this structural silence. Sandeep Kumar Safi's autobiography shows that for Dalit families, the physical labour required for subsistence was more urgent than formal schooling. Safi's parents belonged to the Dhobi caste and earned their livelihood washing the village's clothes; instead of cash, they were given grain or potatoes. These economic constraints compelled numerous Dalit children, Safi among them, to leave school and work as labourers in cities such as Chandigarh and Bengaluru.

The Videha Movement and Translation as Democratic Intervention

The modern revival of Dalit voices in Maithili is associated with the Videha movement's digital and literary initiatives. Maithili literature cannot attain maturity until it recognises the full diversity of its speakers' experiences. The absence of Dalit poetry and prose in Maithili therefore prompted a turn towards writing in other Indian languages.

The Mechanism of Cultural Translation

In Videha, translation is not simply the exchange of words. It is a sociological undertaking that connects forms of consciousness. Its purpose was to introduce Maithili readers to an "aesthetics of protest." Translated works from Odia, Telugu and Gujarati furnished Maithili with a new vocabulary of resistance, freed from the customary tradition of decorative and erotic expression.

The translator's task, as may be seen in the work of P. Jayalakshmi and K. Purushottam, was to negotiate between "foreignisation" and "domestication." In the translation of the Telugu novel Jigiri (Friends Forever), the local colouring of the Telangana dialect and its mixture of Urdu and Telugu were preserved, allowing the plurality of Dalit and nomadic experience to emerge.

A Comparative Perspective: Telugu Dalit Literature in Maithili

Telugu Dalit literature offered a powerful foundation for the Maithili translation project. The Telugu movement became more militant in the 1980s in the aftermath of atrocities such as those at Karamchedu and Chunduru, rejecting established structures of dominance.

Kolakaluri Enoch's "The Crow" (Kaki): An Aesthetics of Untouchability

In "The Crow," Enoch uses the bird as a symbol of the Dalit community. Its protagonist, Bandodu, belongs to the Madiga caste and lives amid acute deprivation. He can catch and eat a crow, an act the wider society considers inauspicious. The Maithili translation captures the very "stench" of this existence, confronting readers with extreme poverty and psychological persecution.

Vinodini's "Black Ink": The Stigma of Identity in the City

Vinodini's "Black Ink" reveals the subtle workings of caste in contemporary urban India. A young girl, Shriya, records good things in her diary in blue ink and bad things in black ink. When she discovers the Dalit identity of a friend, the revulsion that enters her conduct exposes how the stigma of caste is implanted in children's minds.

Peddinti Ashok Kumar's Friends Forever (Jigiri): The Displacement of Nomadic Labour

The novel Jigiri relates the suffering of the Kalandar community, whose livelihood depended on making bears dance. When the government banned bear performances, the principal character, Imam, faced a painful choice: to kill or abandon his bear, Shadul, so that his son's future might be secured and he might obtain two acres of land. The narrative resonates with the suffering of displaced agricultural workers in Mithila and the disappearance of traditional occupations.

Translated Resistance: Gujarati Dalit Poetry in Maithili

Influenced by Ambedkarite philosophy and the Marathi Dalit Panthers movement, Gujarati Dalit poetry is distinguished by its "hard" and "rough-diamond" qualities. Its translation into Maithili established a different literary ground, contrary to the conventions of traditional poetry.

• Anish Garange's "Poster" shows how the Dalit body is used like a "poster" for political advertisement while the individual remains invisible.

• Rajendra Vadel's "Jita" approaches sexual exploitation through the ironic language of "victory," presenting domination over Dalit women as a normalised violence within an upper-caste order.

• Umesh Solanki's "People, Freeze" depicts people becoming "frozen," or inert, in the coldness of social neglect.

The Emergence of Indigenous Dalit Voices in Maithili

The most significant effect of these regional translations was the recognition they brought to indigenous Maithili Dalit writing. Umesh Paswan and Sandeep Kumar Safi were no longer isolated voices: they belonged to a pan-Indian Dalit consciousness.

Umesh Paswan: Rural Reality and the Concept of the Criminal

Umesh Paswan's story collection Mujrim (The Accused) is a "moral testimony" to Dalit life in rural Mithila. He challenges the very word mujrim and demonstrates how that label is imposed on marginalised people by an order vested with power and privilege. His story "Sunanda" depicts a struggle involving education and social stigma, while "Solakanma Pokhair" raises the issue of Dalit exclusion from common resources. His poetry collection Varnit Ras reads the floods of the Kosi, terrorism and youthful anger from a Dalit standpoint.

Sandeep Kumar Safi: The First Dalit Autobiography in Maithili

Sandeep Kumar Safi's Baishakhme Dalanpar represents a historical turning point in Maithili literature. According to Gajendra Thakur, Dalit autobiography had previously been wholly absent from Maithili, and Safi's work filled that gap. Safi gives a moving account of his struggles, the hereditary labour of the Dhobi caste, and an accident he suffered as a migrant worker in Chandigarh, when his foot caught fire.

Redefining Aesthetics: The Tenth and Eleventh Rasas

The entry of Dalit voices has reorganised Maithili aesthetics. Traditional rasa theory emphasised "pleasure," whereas Dalit critics propose rebellion and anger as new rasas.

1. Art for Life's Sake: literature is conceived as an instrument of social transformation.

2. The Tenth and Eleventh Rasas: there is a demand to include "rebellion" and "outrage" (the cry) in the traditional circle of rasas, so that the writing of marginalised communities can be evaluated on its own terms.

3. Collective Experience: the suffering expressed in Dalit literature is not individual but the collective torment of a thousand years.

4. Authenticity of Dialect: instead of "standard" Maithili, writers employ "rustic" or natural speech in order to convey the trauma of marginalised communities authentically.

Conclusion: Towards a Pluralist Maithili Literature

Translated Dalit literature in Maithili demonstrates that the language is entering a period of democratic expansion. The historical absence of written Dalit voices was due not to a lack of creativity but to exclusion by

dominant groups. By translating Dalit literature, the Videha movement has built a "bridge" across that absence. The translations have done more than introduce stories from elsewhere: they have supplied a comparative framework within which Umesh Paswan and Sandeep Kumar Safi could articulate their local experiences. Through digital archives and a redefinition of aesthetics, the contemporary Dalit movement is breaking the "Brahmanical monopoly" over Maithili literature. Maithili is no longer merely the language of scholars; it is becoming a "knowledge society" that reflects the full humanity and struggles of its speakers.

2. The Development and Archival Significance of Translated Literature in Maithili: A Comprehensive Analysis of the Videha Movement

The literary landscape of Maithili, spoken by a population of more than seventeen million across northern Bihar, Jharkhand and Nepal's Terai, is undergoing a revolutionary transformation through the convergence of digital technology and a translation movement. Historically, Maithili literature has been viewed from two distinct standpoints: the "establishment" position, guided since 1965 by institutions such as the Sahitya Akademi, and the "parallel" tradition, which seeks to recover the democratic and popular roots of the language.

At the centre of this transformation stands the Videha movement, represented by its fortnightly electronic journal Videha (ISSN 2229-547X) and extensive digital archive. By assembling a parallel body of original and translated works, the movement has challenged customary forms of dominance and created a globally accessible repository of Maithili's literary heritage. This report examines the ideological basis, technical methods and cultural effects of the movement through an analysis of literature translated into Maithili.

The Historical and Linguistic Context of the Maithili Translation Movement

To understand Maithili literature, it is necessary to understand when and how translation became a powerful instrument of contemporary archival resistance. The language's earliest literary expressions may be found in the Charyapada, composed between 700 and 1300 CE in Sandhya-bhasha by Buddhist siddha poets such as Luipada and Saraha.

The Videha movement makes an important scholarly intervention by distinguishing the celebrated pre-Jyotirishwar composer of the Padavali, Vidyapati, from the Sanskrit/Avahattha author Vidyapati Thakkur (1350–1435 CE). The movement argues that the establishment has narrowed the poet Vidyapati's identity and suppressed its non-Brahmin and rebellious aspects. In this context, translation is more than a linguistic exercise: it is an ideological work of recovery. By translating the experiences of Dalits, women and marginalised communities, the movement is restoring the "beating human heart" to the centre of Maithili literature.

The Videha E-Journal and the Structure of Its Digital Archive

Beginning in 2000 as the Bhalsarik Gachh Yahoo City site, moving to a blog in 2004 and being reorganised as Videha in 2008, the journal represents the longest-running continuous digital presence in Maithili literature. It has published 438 issues and established an extensive digital archive called Videha Petar. The archive is organised into various Sadeha (physical-format) volumes.

Classification of the Videha Archive and Its Translated Books

The organisation of the Videha archive reflects a systematic approach to literary preservation. Its holdings are classified under the headings Archive/Volume, Subject, Description and Reference:

Videha Sadeha 27 — Prose and poetry translated from other languages into Maithili; issues 1–350, with work by Gajendra Thakur and Ravi Bhushan Pathak.

Videha Sadeha 28 — A broad collection of translated prose and poetry, including substantial novels; centred on regional Indian and international writing.

Videha Sadeha 37 — A second volume of translated prose and poetry, with particular emphasis on Telugu, Odia and Gujarati Dalit stories and poems; it also includes Peddinti Ashok Kumar's Jigiri.

Gadya-Padya Bharati Special — A "Translation Special Issue"; issue 97, available in both Devanagari and Tirhuta scripts.

Maithili Pothi — A category of downloadable PDF books, including translations such as Purusha Pariksha and Mohandas.

At the level of script technology, the movement has facilitated digital publication by bringing Mithilakshar (Tirhuta) into the Unicode standard. The archive also contains the first Maithili book in Braille and resources in Maithili sign language.

The Theory and Art of Translation

Translation into Maithili is informed by a sophisticated theoretical approach seeking a balance between cultural fidelity and linguistic accessibility. The essay "Anuvadak Kala" (The Art of Translation) in the Videha archive examines these complexities.

Linguistic and Stylistic Methods

The idea of "tone" is important in Maithili translation. Gajendra Thakur and other translators employ the following strategies:

1. Dynamic Equivalence: the source message is translated so that its effect reaches the Maithili reader's heart.

2. Domestication versus Foreignisation: some texts are adapted to Mithila's rural environment, while others preserve the distinguishing features of the source culture.

3. Paratextual Bridging: footnotes and glossaries explain culturally specific expressions such as pua and panchali.

4. Collaborative Translation: language specialists and creative writers cooperate to capture geographical nuances and ritual practices.

A Case in Social History: The Translation of Jigiri

An important undertaking in the Videha archive is the Maithili translation of Peddinti Ashok Kumar's Telugu novel Jigiri under the title Sada Lel Mitra (Friends Forever). The novel recounts the social history of the Kalandar community, whose members made their living by making bears dance and working as snake charmers. After the Wildlife Protection Act, the community faced an existential crisis. The Maithili translation presents its suffering through regional idioms and rural speech with considerable force.

Regional and International Dimensions

• Pakhalo (Konkani): translated by Dr Shambhu Kumar Singh, this novel by Tukaram Rama Shet addresses Goa's struggle for liberation and the social identities of children of mixed ancestry.

• Chhinnamasta (Hindi): the translation of Prabha Khaitan's novel brings urban feminism and psychological realism into the Maithili archive.

• Bertolt Brecht (German): translations of Brecht's plays introduced theoretical concepts such as "alienation" into Maithili theatre.

• The Qur'an: the translation of the opening chapter, al-Fatiha, reflects Mithila's plural social reality.

The Influence of Jagdish Prasad Mandal

The emergence of Jagdish Prasad Mandal through Videha was a decisive turning point for Maithili fiction. His novel Pangu (recipient of the 2021 Sahitya Akademi Award) and short story "Bisandh" present rural conflict and the realities of the Musahar community without embellishment. English translations of his writings by Thakur, such as Struggles of Life, have carried the movement's ethical voice to a worldwide readership.

Conclusion

The translated literature of the Videha movement constitutes one of modern India's most ambitious linguistic and archival enterprises. Through translation, the "parallel history" movement revises the establishment narrative and safeguards a democratic lineage extending from the Charyapada to contemporary Dalit consciousness. Through its

dedication to the digital archive and the art of translation, Videha seeks to ensure that the "soul of Mithila" remains alive and accessible to the world.

[References: Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's "Indradhanush," Ashok's "Pratilom," and Ramesh's "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio."]

From the perspectives of Dalit literary criticism, Indian criticism, Western criticism, Gangesha's Navya-Nyāya, and the Videha Parallel-History Framework

Introduction

In the modern period of Maithili literature, the revolutionary change in the form and purpose of fiction is generally traced to the emergence of social realism and Dalit consciousness. Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's "Indradhanush," Ashok's "Pratilom" and Ramesh's "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" are not merely three stories; they constitute an extended account of Mithila's changing socioeconomic landscape, class conflict and the struggle for Dalit identity.[1] When these works are studied in the light of Indian and Western literary criticism, Gangesha Upadhyaya's Navya-Nyāya, and the Videha Parallel-History Framework, they reveal concealed layers of literature that elite discourse often overlooks. Fiction has moved beyond Mithila's traditional haveli culture and the khabas institution to reach Sutta, Munra and Kailas, who struggle for the rights due to their labour.

Three works are particularly important to a critical theory of Dalit literature in Maithili's modern fictional tradition: Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's "Indradhanush," Ashok's "Pratilom," and Ramesh's "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio." All three are living documents of economic exploitation in rural Mithila, the injuries inflicted by caste, the cruelty of feudal power, and the resistance of humiliated humanity. The present study examines these works through five distinct critical frameworks:

(1) Dalit literary criticism, which places caste oppression, untouchability and Dalit resistance at the centre;

(2) Indian literary criticism, in the light of rasa theory, dhvani, vakrokti, alaṃkāra and the classical tradition of poetics;

(3) Western literary criticism, from the perspectives of Marxism, postcolonialism, structuralism, feminism and New Historicism;

(4) Gangesha Upadhyaya's Navya-Nyāya, using the philosophical instruments of pramāṇa (means of knowledge), inference, vyāpti (invariable concomitance) and verbal cognition;

(5) the Videha Parallel-History Framework, based on Mithila's history, popular memory, cultural identity and alternative narratives.

Section I: Introductions to the Stories and Textual Analysis

1.1 Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's "Indradhanush" (Rainbow)

(Published in November 1983)

"Indradhanush" is an activist story in Maithili that portrays the awakening of the people against the feudal order in a rural setting in Mithila. Its central character is Anil, a politically conscious young organiser. His associates are Saroj and Mahesh. Opposing them are Kashi Chaudhary (the village landlord and feudal power-holder), Nami Babu (head of the village council), Sutta (a broker), and Munra (a peasant leader).

The story unfolds as follows. Government money is plundered by contractors and the mukhiya in the name of constructing village roads, schools and other public works. To awaken public consciousness, Anil and his group organise a village meeting. It takes place at Kashi Chaudhary's doorstep. Despite resistance from the feudal class, the people come together. In the end there is a lathi-charge, gunfire and repression, but the people's morale is not broken.

The rainbow metaphor is exceptionally profound: just as a rainbow, or panisokha, appears after rain, public consciousness rises after oppression.

1.2 "Pratilom" (Inversion)

"Pratilom" is a dense, multilayered story set in a Brahmin haveli on the occasion of a shraddha ceremony. With great acuity, it lays bare the subtlest cruelties of the caste order, from untouchability to the ostentation of ritual tradition.

Arjun, the central character, is a modern, educated young man who has come to his bauā (elder brother). Budha Malik (Pandit Ganeshwar Jha), the owner of the haveli, represents the old order. Kapileshwar Jha is the principal organiser of the spectacle surrounding the goat. Pradeep, the son, opposes tradition but remains helpless. Manju Buchchi symbolises the oppression of women.

The title "Pratilom" is highly meaningful. It signifies inversion or a reversed order. Those who stand "above" in society are morally "below": priests, landlords and Brahmins themselves refute their supposed superiority through their conduct.

1.3 "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio"

(Published in Katha-Samvad, Darbhanga, 7 July 1990)

This story revolves around Kailas Mandal, a man of the lower social stratum (identified as Shudra), who is left economically and socially

defenceless by his father's untimely death. He had gone from his village to Punjab; now he returns carrying a Philips radio.

Bauā Jha, the Brahmin owner of the haveli, and Surinder and Gajinder, his two strongmen, are the story's antagonists. The Philips radio, symbolising modernity, progress and a new aspiration, ultimately falls victim to a caste conspiracy.

The ending is deeply moving. Bauā Jha, Surinder and Gajinder humiliate Kaila and seize his radio. Yet Kaila's mother—illiterate, elderly and impoverished—stands beside her son at every step. In the final scene, she strikes the radio with a *samdhāni*. She reasons that if the radio is handed over to someone else, she will suffer *dāntī-chanrā*; better to break it outright.

Section II: From the Perspective of Dalit Literary Criticism

Dalit Literary Criticism of Maithili Fiction and the Discourse of Identity

The foundation of Dalit criticism in Maithili is not sympathy but *svānubhūti*—experience lived from within—and resistance. According to its principles, literature should strike at the roots of the caste-based and feudal order and advocate an egalitarian society. In all three stories, Dalits and other marginalised people appear not merely as individual characters but as an awakened class.

2.1 The Theoretical Foundations of Dalit Literary Criticism

Grounded in the intellectual tradition of Dr B. R. Ambedkar, Dalit criticism asks: How authentic is the portrayal of Dalit life in literature? Who is writing, and for whom? How far does such writing contribute to Dalit emancipation? This criticism exposes the internal structures of caste and challenges Brahmanical supremacy in literature.

2.2 Dalit Consciousness in "Indradhanush"

Dalit life in "Indradhanush" is portrayed concretely and analysed in economic terms. Agricultural labourers, Dhanuk Toli and Musahar Toli—these local designations make clear the physical segregation of Dalit communities. The storyteller sharply delineates the socioeconomic gulf between the two classes in the village.

From the standpoint of Dalit criticism, the significant feature of the story is that Dalits are shown not only as victims but as agents of active resistance. When Kashi Chaudhary's armed retainers advance with their lathis, Munra and his companions still do not flee. This "politics of resistance" is a central concern of Dalit literature.

There is nevertheless a limitation: the author tends to reduce caste oppression to a question of class. Dalit critics regard this "class

reductionism" as problematic. Caste is not merely a by-product of class exploitation; it possesses a logic of its own.

The Voice of Dalit Resistance in "Indradhanush"

The form of Dalit awakening visible in Ashok's story "Indradhanush" reflects the political consciousness of the 1980s. Characters such as Sutta, Munra and Yadu no longer bow before the "master"; instead, they demand their *boni*, or wages. From the perspective of Dalit criticism, Sutta's revolt here is directed against the feudal arrogance personified by Kashi Chaudhary. When Sutta says, "We are of the low caste because we earn our bread by working, while those who sit idle and eat are of the high caste," he asserts the dignity of labour. This consciousness draws upon the principle of Dalit criticism that challenges caste superiority on the grounds of labour.

2.3 Untouchability and Brahmanism in "Pratilom"

"Pratilom" is an especially pertinent story for Dalit criticism. Its portrayal of untouchability is remarkably subtle. In a scene involving drinking water at a shraddha feast, the words "Will you take water? Will you drink water, master? Do you want water?" seem to form a small question, yet encompass the full cruelty of the Hindu caste order.

Arjun's helplessness despite his protest raises a central question for Dalit criticism: can an educated Dalit, or a person opposed to caste, attain freedom entirely on his own? Arjun wishes to resist, but he stands alone before the system.

The suggestiveness of the name "Pratilom" is important from the Dalit standpoint: those considered "high" in the caste system are in fact morally low, while those labelled "Shudra" or "untouchable" are superior in human dignity. This is a literary expression of Ambedkarite thought.

Structural Exploitation in "Pratilom"

The depiction of the *khabas* institution in Ashok's "Pratilom" is a serious subject for research in Dalit criticism. The *khabas*, once regarded as the haveli's "property," now wants to change his *jīh* (tongue). For Dalit criticism, "changing one's tongue" is not merely a bodily act but a declaration of linguistic and cultural independence.

2.4 Economic and Caste Exploitation in "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio"

This story brings into focus a particular dimension of Dalit criticism: the confrontation between an object of modernity (the radio) and traditional casteism. The Philips radio is more than a mechanical device. For Kaila and his mother, it embodies the dream of participating in a shared culture. When it is seized, more than a possession is taken away: a person belonging to a lower caste is deprived of the right to participate in the modern world.

Bauā Jha and his strongmen combine caste hatred with economic plunder. Dalit criticism reads the debt trap of 500 rupees imposed on Kaila and the seizure of the radio as a modern form of agrarian servitude.

Structural Exploitation in "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio"

In "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio," Kailas (Kaila) returns from Punjab with his earnings, but the village's feudal order entangles him in its net again. The radio symbolises modernity. Yet when he is forced back into *harbāhī* (bonded agricultural labour), the cruel irony of a "song of freedom" playing on that same radio emerges as a central note of Dalit discourse.

Section III: From the Perspective of Indian Literary Criticism

Indian Literary Criticism: Rasa and Aucitya

In Indian poetics, the realisation of *rasa* produces an enduring emotional disposition in the reader's heart. The experience of *karuṇa-rasa*, or pathos, in "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" fills the reader with indignation against the social system. According to the doctrine of *aucitya* (propriety), every element of a literary work should be balanced. Yet, through the portrayal of *anaucitya* (impropriety or social injustice), the storytellers expose society's true face. According to *dhvani* theory, the very title "Indradhanush" carries a suggested meaning: it evokes the ineffectual colours of politics and their transience.

3.1 Rasa Theory and the Emotional Ground of the Stories

The theory of *rasa*, originating in Acharya Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra*, applies to prose fiction as well. The dominant rasas in these three stories are as follows:

"Indradhanush": *vīra-rasa* (the heroic enthusiasm of popular struggle), *karuṇa-rasa* (the depiction of poverty), and *raudra-rasa* (anger against feudal repression).

"Pratilom": *bībhatsa-rasa* (the repellent portrayal of untouchability), *karuṇa-rasa* (Arjun's helplessness), and humour and satire directed at the ostentation of the shraddha ritual.

The Videha Framework: Story, Expression and Effect

Component of the framework	Expression in the story	Effect
Subaltern consciousness	Revolt by Suttā and Munarā	Decline of traditional power
People's history	Discussion of the khabās (hereditary domestic-service) genealogy	Recovery of the histories of disadvantaged groups
Realist depiction	Bomb attacks and violence in the village	End of the myth of romantic Mithila
Philosophical analysis	Logical application of Navya-Nyāya	Greater intellectual seriousness in literature

"Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio": predominantly *karuṇa-rasa*; *śānta-rasa* (the forbearance of Kaila's mother at the end); and intense anger and the emotion of separation.

3.2 The Theory of Dhvani: In the Light of Anandavardhana

According to *dhvani* theory, the power of suggestion (*vyañjanā-śakti*) is supreme in poetry. These stories employ suggestion with considerable skill.

The name "Indradhanush" carries symbolic suggestion. A rainbow has seven colours; likewise, the discussion identifies seven caste communities in Mithila's society: Brahmins, Kayasthas, Yadavs, Dhanuks, Musahars, Khatbes and Amats (Amatyas). Just as the seven colours combine to create a beautiful and luminous spectacle, popular consciousness dreams of attaining such unity.

In grammar as well as philosophy, *pratilom* denotes a prohibited or reversed order. The title suggests a society that has inverted its natural moral order—justice, equality and love—and has consequently itself become *pratilom*.

In "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio," the radio suggests modernity and the dream of moving between classes. Even the Western brand name "Philips" suggests that so-called global modernity remains beyond the reach of Dalits.

3.3 Vakrokti and Satire: The Tradition of Acharya Kuntaka

In the light of Kuntaka's *Vakroktijīvita*, all three stories make skilful use of *vakrokti*, or oblique expression.

In "Pratilom," the conversation about taking water during the shraddha ceremony—"Will you take water? Will you drink water, master?"—is a question whose very simplicity is oblique. Ostensibly it concerns water; in meaning, it concerns caste purity and pollution. This brief exchange suggests the entire philosophy of the Hindu caste order.

When Munra says in "Indradhanush," "Forgive me, sir," the apparently deferential phrase is in reality an ironic act of resistance. He has not been broken within; under pressure from circumstances, he is merely uttering the conventional words of submission.

3.4 The Folk-Tale Tradition and the Style of Maithili Fiction

All three stories bear the deep influence of Mithila's folk-narrative tradition. Their forms of dialogue, their selection of symbols and their vivid depiction of rural settings derive from Maithili folk literature. Just as Vidyapati's *Padavali* combines erotic love and devotion, these stories combine social reality with human compassion.

Section IV: From the Perspective of Western Literary Criticism

A Study in the Light of Indian and Western Critical Theory

When this triad of Maithili stories is examined against Indian theories such as rasa, dhvani and vakrokti, and Western approaches such as Marxism, deconstruction and existentialism, the philosophical depth contained within them becomes clear.

Western Literary Criticism: Marxism and Deconstruction

In Western criticism, Marxism explains class struggle. In "Indradhanush," the conflict between the inhabitants of the Dalit hamlet and the village's landowning class is a conflict between the Marxist proletariat and bourgeoisie. From the standpoint of deconstruction, "Pratilom" breaks apart the established master–servant binary. The influence of existentialism can be discerned in "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio," where Kaila struggles for his own existence but is turned into an object by the prevailing system.

4.1 Marxist Literary Criticism

Gramsci's concept of cultural hegemony makes the interpretation of "Indradhanush" particularly clear. In the village, Kashi Chaudhary is not merely all-powerful economically; he possesses cultural power as well. Meetings take place at his doorway, people seek his blessings, and his words are accorded legitimacy. This is cultural hegemony.

From the standpoint of Lukács's realism, the depiction of social reality in all three stories is highly credible and historically concrete. The Brahmin landlord's doorway, the agricultural labourers' hamlet, the helplessness of a young man returning from Punjab—all are literary expressions of Mithila's historical reality in the 1980s and 1990s.

4.2 Postcolonial Literary Criticism

In the light of Frantz Fanon's ideas in The Wretched of the Earth, "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" portrays a colonised mind. Kaila travels to Punjab but does not become estranged from his community. He brings back a radio, an object of modernity, yet his social position remains unchanged.

Under Gayatri Spivak's concept of the subaltern—the powerless groups at society's margins—the subaltern speaks in each of the three stories. Arjun's mother, known as Gamwali, in "Pratilom"; the women of the Dhanuk hamlet in "Indradhanush"; and Kaila's mother in the Philips-radio story are all subaltern figures whose voices are seldom heard in the mainstream. The storytellers nevertheless give them a voice. Even so, Spivak's question remains valid: can those who are oppressed speak in their own voice? Can the Subaltern Speak?

4.3 Structuralism and Poststructuralism

On the basis of Saussurean linguistics, the pairs "master" and "labourer," "pandit" and "Shudra," and "haveli" and "hamlet" constitute binary oppositions upon which the narrative structures of all three stories depend.

From the standpoint of Derridean deconstruction, the title "Pratilom" dismantles its traditional binary opposition. The distinction between "high" and "low" loses its meaning when those held to be "high" behave in morally "low" ways.

4.4 Feminist Literary Criticism

In the light of Simone de Beauvoir's The Second Sex, the female characters in all three stories are deeply significant but occupy a secondary position. In "Pratilom," Gamwali and Manju Buchchi both live, in their different circumstances, under patriarchal restrictions. Kaila's mother in the Philips-radio story is the most patient and morally steadfast character, yet her agency is limited.

The near absence of female characters from "Indradhanush" also raises a critical question: are women treated as naturally excluded from narratives of popular struggle?

4.5 New Historicism

Stephen Greenblatt's New Historicism situates literature within historical processes. "Indradhanush" was written in November 1983, a period of upheaval in Indian politics. Against the background of the Bihar movement, Naxalism and the closing years of Indira Gandhi's rule, its narrative of popular struggle is the product of a particular historical moment.

"Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" was written in 1990, when the Khalistan movement in Punjab, the Mandal Commission controversy and the beginnings of economic liberalisation were part of the political landscape. Kaila's journey to Punjab and the symbolism of the radio therefore possess a concrete historical context.

Three Stories: Publication Context and Social Problems

Story	Date of publication / reading	Geographical setting	Social problem
Indradhanush (Rainbow)	November 1983	Rural Mithila	Caste violence; vote-bank politics
Pratilom (Against the Grain)	Modern period	Mansion and Dalit settlement	Khabās service tradition; struggle for identity
Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio	July 1990	From Punjab to the village	Debt trap; the grotesque side of modernity

Section V: From the Perspective of Gangesha Upadhyaya's Navya-Nyāya

5.1 A General Introduction to Navya-Nyāya

Gangesha Upadhyaya's Tattvacintāmaṇi (he was active around 1320 CE, in the early fourteenth century) is among Mithila's most influential philosophical works. It gives Nyāya philosophy a rigorous logical foundation. The four principal instruments of knowledge considered here are:

(1) Pratyakṣa: knowledge obtained through direct perception.

(2) Anumāna: inference based on vyāpti, or an invariable, universal relation.

(3) Upamāna: knowledge obtained through comparison.

(4) Śabda: knowledge obtained from the words of a trustworthy speaker.

5.2 Literary Evidence as Perceptual Testimony

The epistemic instrument of pratyakṣa, or direct perception, can be applied to literary criticism in this way: what the storyteller has seen and experienced is presented as perceptual evidence. In "Indradhanush," the statement "Even lathis have made their way into the houses of this village" constitutes direct social testimony.

In "Pratilom," the procedure of offering and drinking water at the śrāddha feast, and each scene seen through Arjun's eyes, form a narrative movement from the indeterminate perception (nirvikalpaka pratyakṣa) of Navya-Nyāya to determinate perception (savikalpaka pratyakṣa).

5.3 Inference as a Means of Knowledge and the Relation of Vyāpti

Four Approaches to Dalit Literary Criticism

Critical perspective	Principal theory	Application to the stories
Indian poetics	Rasa, dhvani and aucitya	Depiction of feudal irony and compassion
Western criticism	Marxism and deconstruction	Class struggle and the dismantling of entrenched power
Dalit criticism	Lived experience and resistance	Opposition to the khabās tradition and defence of identity
Navya-Nyāya	Perception, inference and delimiters	Exposure of social argument and artifice

Inference is of the greatest importance in Navya-Nyāya. Vyāpti, universal concomitance—as in the proposition "Where there is smoke, there is fire"—forms the basis of this method of reasoning.

"Indradhanush" establishes such a relation on the social plane: "Wherever there is a feudal order, there is exploitation." Each episode in the story demonstrates this relation: the embezzlement of panchayat funds,

dishonesty over roads and thoroughfares, and the denial of minimum wages to agricultural labourers.

In "Pratilom," the concomitant relation is: "Wherever there is Brahmanical ostentation, there is the degradation of human beings." The old master, Kapileshwar Jha and other characters demonstrate this relation through the Navya-Nyāya triad of pakṣa (subject), sādhya (that which is to be established) and hetu (reason).

5.4 Upādhi (Limiting Condition) and Social Justice

In Navya-Nyāya, upādhi, a limiting condition or qualifier, is an important concept that restricts or refines the scope of a relation of vyāpti. In Kailas Mandal's story, caste functions as an upādhi defining the extent and form of exploitation.

This philosophical analysis yields an important conclusion: in all three stories, social reality appears as a logically ordered system, structurally determined. On the literary plane, it reflects the Navya-Nyāya logic of jñātatā (knownness) and ajñātatā (unknownness).

5.5 Śabda-pramāṇa and Testimony from the People

Śabda-pramāṇa—knowledge derived from the word of a trustworthy authority—is the voice of the people in these stories. In "Indradhanush," Anil addresses a public meeting, and his words become authoritative testimony for the assembly. In "Pratilom," Pradip's questions and answers constitute a Navya-Nyāya dialogue founded upon verbal testimony.

Gangesha's Navya-Nyāya and Narrative Analysis

The Navya-Nyāya of Gangesha Upadhyaya, one of Mithila's intellectual glories, is not merely a philosophy; it is a subtle instrument of reasoning that can be used in literary analysis. Its epistemology considers perception, inference, comparison and verbal testimony as means of valid knowledge.

The Conflict Between Perception and Appearance

According to Gangesha, perception arises through the senses. In "Indradhanush," when the protagonist comes to the village, a misapprehension accompanies his direct perception of it. He believes that the village is as it was before, but this apparent perception breaks down when he hears about bombs and lathis. The Navya-Nyāya defect of overextension (ativyāpti) becomes evident here: the traditional definition of village peace now encompasses a world encircled by violence.

Avacchedaka and Counterpositiveness: Kailas's Radio

The Navya-Nyāya concepts of avacchedaka (delimitor) and pratiyogitā (counterpositiveness) are subtle. In "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio," the radio is the delimitor of modernity for Kailas; for Baua Jha, however, the same radio provides the basis for the counterpositiveness of Kailas's "debt."

When Kaila smashes the radio with a peg, he establishes abhāva (absence): the absence of the radio signifies the symbolic ending of the humiliation and debt associated with it.

Inference and Vyāpti: The Logic of "Pratilom"

Arjun's reasoning in "Pratilom" belongs to the process of inference. He wishes to look like Baua because his assumed universal relation is that a person with red lips and a clean appearance is a "master." Yet society's cruel upādhi, its limiting condition, consigns him once again to the category of khabās, the hereditary servant.

Section VI: From the Perspective of the Videha Parallel-History Framework

6.1 The Videha Parallel-History Framework: An Introduction

In the philosophy of Mithila's history, "Videha Parallel History" is an innovative critical instrument. The framework rests on the assumption that, apart from the histories of the state, government and mainstream historical narratives, Mithila has a parallel history in which popular memory, Dalit experience, women's narratives and the truths of neglected communities are preserved.

The word "Videha" (an ancient name associated with Janakpur and Mithila) also carries the sense "beyond the body" or "beyond the physical." This parallel history preserves those truths that were never entered into government documents or official histories.

The Videha Parallel-History Framework: A New Discourse

The Videha Parallel-History Framework advanced by Gajendra Thakur challenges the established history of Maithili literature and institutes a parallel discourse. It makes room, above all, for voices neglected by the Darbhanga Raj and other institutional structures.

Subaltern History and Maithili Fiction

According to the Videha framework, Mithila's real history is not confined to accounts of royal courts; rather, it survives in nārāśaṃsī, narratives of people's lives and character. "Indradhanush," attributed here to Ashok, portrays the history of a village's Dalit hamlets, suppressed beneath the political rainbow. In "Pratilom," the lineage of the khabās family, from Manshi Mandar to Arjun, forms part of this same parallel history, removed from the main current of historical writing.

Principal Propositions of the Videha Framework and Their Narrative Application

1. Deconstruction of the canon: challenging established literary standards. Centring the struggle of a Dalit character in "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" is an achievement of this framework. 2. Linguistic autonomy: the

Videha framework values forms of Maithili widespread among ordinary people. In all three stories, the language, idioms and village speech of everyday life contribute to the democratisation of literature. 3. Documentary realism: the Videha framework treats a story as a social document. "Indradhanush" is a serious record of the political and social condition of a village in 1983.

Narrative Character Analysis and Social Structure

The choice of characters and their conduct in all three stories reveal society's changing values.

Characters in "Indradhanush": Struggle and Illusion

Anil: a middle-class young man who fears the changes taking place in the village but is ready to struggle.

Sutta: a symbol of Dalit revolt, no longer prepared to bow down.

Satinath Jha: a figure of political intervention who makes use of Dalit awakening for electoral votes.

Characters in "Pratilom": From Servitude to Revolt

Arjun: a fourteen-year-old boy born into the khabās tradition but possessed of a strong sense of personal identity.

Gamwali (Arjun's mother): a symbol of traditional helplessness, compelled by poverty to remain connected with the haveli.

Jabhira: a representative of a younger Dalit generation that now challenges its master by figuratively seizing him by the tongue.

Characters in "Philips Radio": Sacrifices of Modernity

Kailas (Kaila): a hopeful young man who has seen the world outside but becomes entangled in the feudal mechanisms of his village.

Baua Jha: the cruel face of feudal exploitation, practising oppression while speaking sweetly.

Surinder and Gajinder: the landlord's strongmen and conspirators, who exploit others under a pretence of friendship.

The Linguistic and Formal Beauty of Maithili Fiction

In these Maithili stories, form and language are not merely means of communication; they constitute a discourse in themselves.

The language of "Indradhanush": Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary employs a descriptive mode. Short utterances such as "Even bombs have reached us now" intensify the tension in the village.

The language of "Pratilom": Ashok employs a psychological mode. Arjun's thought—"My lips have turned red ... do I look like Baua now, or not?"—

expresses both his internalised sense of inferiority and his desire to escape it.

The language of "Philips Radio": satire and irony abound. A "song of freedom" on the radio, juxtaposed with Kaila's harbāhī (bonded agricultural labour), is a contradiction that demonstrates the artistic power of Maithili fiction.

Statistical References and Historical Periods

The periods in which these stories were written matter to the development of Maithili fiction. "Indradhanush" belongs to 1983, when violence and caste polarisation were increasing in rural Bihar politics. "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" belongs to 1990, when globalisation and growing contact with the outside world were changing the village economy.

6.2 Mithila's Historical Context

Mithila's history has three layers: (a) political history—kings, zamindars and feudal lords; (b) cultural history—Vidyapati, Gangesha and heroes of folk ballads; and (c) social history—the caste system, relations over land and Mithila Brahmanism. Literature, too, has been written in three corresponding ways.

The Videha Parallel-History Framework asks: where is the "fourth dimension" in Maithili literature? Where is the history written with Musahars, Dhanuks, Yadavs, Kurmis, Tatmas, Dusadhs (Dudhvanshis) and Amatyas at its centre?

6.3 "Indradhanush" and Mithila's Agrarian History

Read through the Videha Parallel-History Framework, "Indradhanush" ceases to be merely a story and becomes a literary record of the land movements in Mithila during the 1970s and 1980s.

It was written in the period of Mithila's land-reform movements, the slogan "The land belongs to the tiller," and Naxalite influence. Kashi Chaudhary is not merely a fictional character; he is a historical representative of Mithila's contemporary feudal system.

Within the Videha framework, the story forms a chapter of Mithila's parallel history, unrecorded in official gazetteers but living in popular memory.

6.4 "Pratilom" and the History of Mithila Brahmanism

The history of Brahmanism in Mithila is long and complex. The Mithila Brahmin pañjī, or genealogical register, regulates marriage relations on the basis of caste and is perhaps one of the most intricate caste-based bureaucracies in the world.

In "Pratilom," the śrāddha ceremony of Pandit Ganeshwar Jha is, in effect, a live documentary record of this historical Brahmanical order. Lutan Mandar, Tholai Mandar and Raudi Mandar represent the lineage-based social structure of Mithila at the time.

From the standpoint of Videha parallel history, Arjun's resistance is a literary echo of Mithila's internal reform movements. Whether one considers the progressive movement of Mithila Vidyapith or organisations struggling for social justice, these struggles belong to the historical record; "Pratilom" preserves them in the form of a story.

6.5 "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio": The History of Migrant Workers

One of the most important chapters of Mithila's modern history is the history of migrant labour. Hundreds of thousands of people travelled from Bihar and Mithila to Punjab, Delhi and Mumbai. The history of this internal migration is largely absent from mainstream historiography.

"Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" is an invaluable document of that parallel history. Kaila went to Punjab, worked there with Bhaggu Mallah, earned money and bought a radio. This is not merely an individual story; it symbolises the collective experience of migrant workers from Mithila.

Within the Videha framework, the story becomes a chapter in "the parallel history of Mithila's migrant workers"—a history that lives neither in official statistics nor in academic research papers, but in literature itself.

Section VII: Comparative Analysis and Synthesis

7.1 The Interrelationship of the Three Stories

A deep relationship connects the three stories: they present three different dimensions of the same society in Mithila.

"Indradhanush"—the political dimension: popular struggle, organisation and opposition to feudalism.

"Pratilom"—the religious and cultural dimension: śrāddha, the veneration of caste and the ostentation of tradition.

"Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio"—the economic and individual dimension: migration, aspiration and caste oppression.

Taken together, the three provide a three-dimensional portrayal of contemporary life in Mithila.

7.2 Diversity of Style and Language

The linguistic styles of the three stories differ. "Indradhanush" uses colloquial Maithili, collective dialogue and slogans—the language of the people. "Pratilom" employs a comparatively literary, Sanskrit-influenced Maithili, which also reflects the speech of its Brahmin characters. "Kailas

Mandal's Philips Radio" mixes Maithili and Hindi, capturing the linguistic reality of contact between town and countryside.

7.3 A Synthesis of the Five Frameworks

All five frameworks approach the same truth from five directions. Dalit criticism says that caste oppression is primary. Indian poetics says that rasa, dhvani and alaṅkāra create the stories' literary beauty. Western criticism says that class, caste, gender and history are interwoven. Navya-Nyāya says: demonstrate through reasoning that exploitation is a systemic reality, not an arbitrary occurrence. The Videha framework says that Mithila possesses its own distinctive history, preserved in these literary works.

Epilogue

"Indradhanush," "Pratilom" and "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" are three golden strands of Maithili literature, rising in a moment from "literature" into "history," and from "history" into "philosophy." Examined through all five critical frameworks, they reveal the following:

(1) The question of human dignity is paramount in these stories, whether the person concerned is Dalit, a woman or a labourer of the poorer classes.

(2) Mithila's distinctive social and cultural setting lends these stories universality. They are not Mithila's alone; they are stories of every corner of Indian society in which human beings are crushed within the triangle of caste, class and gender.

(3) These stories form a bridge between literary excellence and social commitment. This is not "art for art's sake" but "art for life's sake."

(4) Viewed through the Videha Parallel-History Framework, all three stories write the history of Mithila that official historiography has been unable to write.

Finally, Gangesha Upadhyaya's Navya-Nyāya contains the concept of siddhi, achievement through valid knowledge. The siddhi attained by reading, reflecting upon and analysing these three stories is this: caste, class and the degradation of human beings constitute a system that is logically, historically and morally unjust, and literature is the most powerful form of resistance to it.

Conclusion: The Future of Maithili Fiction and the Parallel Tradition

These stories by Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary, Ashok and Ramesh take Maithili literature beyond an elitist enclosure and bring it into contact with the realities of ordinary people. The political realism of "Indradhanush," the struggle for identity in "Pratilom," and the economic irony of "Philips Radio" together create a parallel history of Mithila. When the stories are analysed using the logical methods of

Gangesha Upadhyaya's Navya-Nyāya, literature is no longer merely an object of sentiment; it becomes an intellectual discourse. The Videha framework gives this discourse a systematic foundation, integrating Dalit thought, class consciousness and the contradictions of modernity. This development in Maithili fiction looks towards a future "rainbow" (panisokhā) whose colours do not fade, and in which every "Kaila" and "Arjun" has the full right to preserve his own "Philips radio" and his identity. Through these stories, Maithili literature advances alongside global discussions of the subaltern.

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APPENDIX 2

Jyotsna Phanija — An Exploration of Caste Conflict in Selected Maithili Stories

[Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's "Indradhanush" ("The Rainbow"), Ashok Kumar Jha's "Pratilom" ("Anticurrent"), and Ramesh Jha's "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio," in Contemporary Maithili Short Stories. Edited by Murari Madhusudan Thakur. New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 2005.]

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Jyotsna Phanija

Dr Jyotsna Phanija, from the quiet village of Kaikaluru in Andhra Pradesh, is a profound testament to the power of the written word against the silence imposed by circumstance. She is Assistant Professor of English at ARSD College, University of Delhi. In 2016, at the young age of twenty-five, she earned her PhD from the English and Foreign Languages University (EFLU), Hyderabad. Dr Phanija's work constitutes a subtle exploration of communities pushed to the margins. Her research makes its way through the tremors of postcolonial literature, particularly examining the intersection of gender and "madness," which she treats not as a medical deficiency but as a rebellious form of resistance. This voice of resurgence is present throughout her varied literary portfolio:

Poetry and translation: From her first poetry collection, Ceramic Evening (2016), to her delicate translations of Telugu poetry in Crimson Lamp (2015) and Stoned Song (2019), she bridges linguistic and emotional distances.

Editorial vision: With Nivedita N., she edited The World I Write In (2016), an important anthology that places the voices of visually impaired writers at its centre.

A multidimensional reach: Her creative gifts extend to fiction, academic articles and essays, often composed in the spare moments of her life as a singer. She embodies the confluence of tributaries of caste, gender and disability. Dr Phanija's identity is situated at a complex crossroads. In a world where the combination of being a woman, visually impaired and of a lower caste frequently produces a systemic lack of resources, she does not merely endure; she speaks out. Her life and writing resist silence, transforming the difficulties of her intersectional reality into a courageous, poetic cry.

An Exploration of Caste Conflict in Selected Maithili Stories

Caste divides people into privileged and underprivileged classes, creating distinctions of superiority and inferiority. These form two separate worlds that can never become one; for a very long time they have governed the human capacity to think and reflect. Literature gives voice to the pain of being subjected to caste oppression, to the terror and violence arising from caste difference, and to the "infection of caste" that afflicts humanity. Some Maithili stories translated into English embody caste oppression in metaphorical terms. Set in rural surroundings, they depict the condition of being subjected to caste oppression and present gender and caste as a "double oppression," expressing suffering and anguish through poetic images. They bring into relief caste conflicts generated by physical location and by economic, political and cultural concerns, as well as the violence that pervades them as a symbol of existence.

To speak of caste is a complex undertaking, for it is difficult to delineate pain and suffering while fearlessly portraying the inequalities of contemporary society. As Sharmila Rege writes, writing about caste can sometimes seem tantamount to betraying the nation. In her words, "Even in the postcolonial period, public and political expression of caste was regarded as a backward-looking ideology that slowed the momentum of class struggle and was also considered a betrayal of the nation" (Rege 39). To write about caste is to shatter the illusion of the justice or virtue of Indian civilisation.

The selected stories — Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's "The Rainbow," Ashok Kumar Jha's "Anticurrent," and Ramesh Jha's "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" — investigate caste conflict in the context of an unrestrained civilisation, or a society divided by caste. All three share a perspective: they recognise caste as class while also dividing thinkers who regard caste as equivalent to class. In a postcolonial register, class and caste alternately torment the inhabitants. The abolition of caste difference may be recorded on paper, but the class consciousness that sustains the presence of caste continues to prey upon those who suffer. These stories show how members of a particular group are denied freedom, how their childhood is stolen, how their sense of self-acceptance is called into question, and how they attempt to struggle against an unjust social system.

1. An Analysis of Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's Story "The Rainbow" (Indradhanush)

Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary's "The Rainbow," translated by Rajanand Jha, exemplifies the complete transformation of a village affected by caste conflict. The story foregrounds the declining social identity of the upper caste, while the narrator is still engaged in unlearning the practices of caste

superiority and high-and-low distinctions. He is adjusting to a new order in which his status as "high" is being challenged.

The narrator, who lives away from his village, returns to comfort his mother. She lives alone in the village and feels unsafe because of the continuous quarrels between upper and lower castes. This situation threatens the peace that once prevailed there. Although the title "The Rainbow" (Indradhanush) symbolises beauty and joy, it actually points towards social unrest.

The narrator's mother knows nothing of politics. She is neutral towards the caste situation but is concerned about the danger facing the village's future. The narrator, on the other hand, is prepared to distance himself from upper-caste dominance. But Anil, a relative of the narrator and a prominent young upper-caste man, is unwilling to accept equality in society. He tries to subdue lower-caste people through violence. Anil firmly believes that "a classless society can never be attained; it is only an illusion."

Is Anil speaking the truth? Is a classless society merely imaginary? Other elements in the story lend support to this harsh reality. The village's division between rulers and ruled, masters and labourers, together with each group's attempt to establish its self-respect, exposes the many layers of caste conflict.

There is also a third group: wealthy landlords, moneylenders and counterfeit social reformers who exploit caste conflict for their own interests. Finally, there is a fourth group, consisting of innocent villagers of both castes who bear the blows of this system. The story makes tangible the multidimensional and complex nature of caste conflict, within which humanity is continually crushed.

The story depicts a change in which upper-caste people struggle to accept the reality that one human being cannot be held in another's possession like property. The narrator recalls, for instance, that the villagers can no longer address him as "master." In its refined form, the story announces the end of the "master–slave" relationship between upper and lower castes.

Alongside this portrayal, the story speaks of the false mantle of equality worn by the wealthy. Pseudo-communists such as Mahakant Jha and Bhutta Jha seek to teach labourers the lessons of equality. They incite labourers against their employers. Their purpose is not to help the poor but to establish themselves as social reformers, contest elections and win popular support. As a result of their scheme, labourers stop working in Saroj Bhaiya's fields for three months. When Saroj repeatedly summons the wife of his labourer Parbodhan to his house to collect her wages, a movement begins.

Caste is an unscientific method of division that prevents the full participation of the whole of society. The village depicted in this story is a microcosm of the nation, where the political struggle over caste generates a seemingly endless psychological conflict for the individual. The upper-caste villagers are stunned by the "rebellious" conduct of the lower castes. They feel that the supreme position they once enjoyed will now remain only a fairy tale. Saroj believes that the lower castes have become independent because the upper castes lack unity among themselves. His inherited upper-caste attitudes compel him to feel superior and to assert a master's rights over those of lower castes.

The story discusses a political struggle in which calculating members of the lower castes take improper advantage of the suffering of their own people and use it for economic gain. Sutta Khatbe and Munra are blamed for spreading violence in the village and bringing hardship to the poor. Sutta Khatbe, of the Khatbe-Dhanuk community, takes a thick stick in his hand and intimidates Kashi Chaudhary. Displaying his full anger, he warns Kashi Babu that if he refuses to pay their wages, the consequences will be grave. The sequence seems theatrical because it shows only Kashi Babu's momentary defeat. On the following day, Sutta's father apologises to Kashi Babu, revealing that the older generation still believes in upper-caste supremacy.

At a deeper level, this incident also foregrounds the persecution of innocent people. The upper-caste villagers become violent in their anger. Sutta comes carrying a stick and tells his father to stop pleading before Anil. In his rage, he questions the upper-caste people: "I will go on abusing the Brahmins." Striking out with his stick, he asks, "We earn by the sweat of our brows, so we have become a low caste, while these lepers, who sit around doing nothing, have become a high caste?" (Chaudhary 153). His question asserts the right to equal respect for his labour.

The story takes a violent turn when a crowd mobilised by Anil attempts to seize Sutta, but he escapes. The crowd catches Sutta's father, Yadua, and beats him. Munra threatens Kashi Babu and demands that Yadua be released from the crowd. They let Yadua go, but when they cannot find Munra they attack his wife and tear her sari. Munra remains hidden inside the house. In this situation Munra's wife becomes the actual victim, while her husband remains safely concealed. Likewise, the elderly Yadua suffers the violence generated by caste conflict, while his son escapes.

Lower-caste people then begin to attack the upper castes. "Poor, helpless Vishwanath Mishra, who was sitting in his courtyard, was picked up and flung away like a frog. As Pandit Musahar Jha returned from the temple with a basket of flowers in his hand, he was thrown to the ground" (Chaudhary 153). This political struggle victimises innocent people and

leaves them powerless. The shrewd members of both groups play their caste politics in safety, abandoning innocent villagers to their suffering. Nami Babu, a village moneylender, pretends to remain neutral in this situation, a posture that is still extremely dangerous for the village's future.

Cunning upper-caste people play upon the fears of lower-caste villagers so that they can become known as reformers, like Satinath Jha. Satinath Jha, a widower and member of the Lok Dal, feigns liberalism and manipulates caste politics for personal advantage. The narrator, a conscientious observer, is appalled by these divisions. He asks, "What is all this? A resurgence of Dalits? Caste conflict and class struggle? For whose sake? Why are these so-called leaders poisoning the social fabric in the name of caste to create their vote banks?" (Chaudhary 155). Caste has become a weapon in the hands of vote-seekers. By speaking of caste in these lines and exposing the true faces of politicians, pseudo-communists, the rich, the calculating and powerful, and those who safely play the game of neutrality, Chaudhary appears to see democracy as little more than a dream.

The story criticises the harassment of the poor caused by caste conflict, as the daughter-in-law of Vaishampavalli bitterly comments upon her situation:

Sutta drives a rickshaw in the town, and Munra goes from village to village working as a mason. They have no worries. They have left us here in the middle of it all and are enjoying themselves. We have nothing to eat. Our children are hungry! You people show us no pity. You have dismissed us from household work. Our cattle will die without fodder. They graze on this embankment because we are forbidden to graze them in the fields and orchards. They will certainly die. All this is happening because of Sutta and Munra. (Chaudhary 161)

Likewise, caste conflict creates tension among the upper-caste middle class because they require labourers for their agricultural work. Munna Babu, belonging to the upper middle class, sums up the entire conflict in these words:

Kashi Babu now has his bread buttered on both sides. He will certainly make plenty of money out of this. Nami Babu is already on his side. As for Munra and Sutta, he will summon them tomorrow and shake hands with them. They are from his own neighbourhood. The rest of us villagers will be made fools of. Kashi has no concern for his fields and farmland. Your land will lie fallow while he enjoys himself. (Chaudhary 159)

Thus this rainbow is a restless rainbow, furnished with cruel wings and covering the entire sky, in a world where politicians are mechanising the national interest. The story raises the question whether freedom is real or merely an illusion, for innocent people belonging to neither camp are

being deprived of their livelihoods. Playing hide-and-seek between the concepts of caste and class, the story strikes at the roots of the caste system.

2. An Analysis of Ashok's Story "Anticurrent" (Pratilom)

Ashok Kumar Jha's short story "Anticurrent," translated by Sanjeev Kumar Chaudhary, presents caste conflict and a stolen childhood. Arjun, Dhanmanti's fourteen-year-old son, has inherited from his mother a sense of submission to the upper castes, because people from his own community ridicule him. Yet this is also a time of resurgence, when movements against upper-caste domination are gathering force. Arjun is willing to accept the leftovers of his former employer's household, although members of his caste tell him that they should no longer take leftover food from the upper castes. "The women barbers no longer accept leftover food. People of their caste forbid them to work in the mansion as male and female barbers; they regard it as humiliating" (Jha 239). As in the struggle depicted through hunger and starvation in "The Rainbow," Arjun and his helpless mother work against the wishes of their own caste community in order to satisfy their hunger. When Arjun goes to his former master Pandit Ganeshwar Jha's shraddha ceremony, where large quantities of delicious food will be served, he is mocked by people of his own caste. Their ridicule torments his innocent mind.

The story offers a striking example of economic conflict: while Baua Jha's family and numerous relatives enjoy their meals and waste great quantities of food, Arjun's household does not have even a pinch of sugar with which to make tea. Arjun's exhausted body longs for a cup of tea in the bitter winter cold, but his circumstances prevent him from having one. His mother cannot give him tea because there is no sugar in the house. He is repeatedly sent to the mansion for various tasks, and he struggles for a mere cup of tea. This desperate situation depicts hunger in all its cruelty.

Food habits constitute another distinction dividing people by caste. The story portrays changes from one dietary practice to another in an ironic manner. Arjun's father, Lutan Marar, had given up eating meat. He had accepted a kanthi, a devotional necklace, from an ascetic. His former master and mistress were angry with him, but he remained a vegetarian. Dhanmanti connects his premature death with his change of dietary practice. Because vegetarian food is treated as a marker of a particular caste and its identity, Lutan Marar is criticised for attempting to change his original way of life.

The story foregrounds the way people are compelled to endure injustice in the name of tradition. In praising his employer, Arjun imitates Baua Jha's ideas. Through this process of admiration he loses his own sense of self. One example occurs when Arjun insists that everyone should wash their

hands after drinking tea, continually offering the guests a water vessel for that purpose. Those present criticise him for behaving like a pandit, like a member of the upper caste. The imitation of others is itself one reason why the caste order continues for so long. Admiration produces self-hatred and lowers one's estimate of one's own identity. The story identifies the psychological struggle in which Arjun and his mother are entangled in a complex form of self-disgust: every small act of imitating their masters or adopting their habits gives them a temporary status as members of the accepted group. Although Dhanmanti criticises Lutan Marar for changing his diet, she is herself fascinated by her son's upper-class habits. This inability to accept oneself psychologically fragments her. Another reason for Arjun's enslavement is his fear of his master. As a young boy he thinks of his life, his mother's helplessness, his family and their need for food. He is a troubled child who needs the warmth of affection rather than orders, and praise for the little tasks he performs. As a disadvantaged child on many levels, Arjun's stolen childhood is a failure of the nation.

The story reaches a significant turning point when Baua Jha's arrogance is challenged by Jawahar, a boy whom Arjun has brought to work at the shraddha ceremony for a wage of twenty rupees. An excess of lime in the betel leaf cuts Arjun's tongue, and Jawahar tells Baua Jha to replace it. Baua Jha's high-caste status, his ability to read sacred scriptures and his longstanding faith in purity are all challenged. "...This Jawahara, this tiny little boy, is challenging me. He is asking me to change Arjun's tongue! As if it were some nut or bolt" (Jha 255). Baua Jha knows that replacing Arjun's tongue is impossible, and he is filled with intolerable rage. Arjun's cut tongue is a metaphor for the fractured identity he has been forced to endure. His father is gone, his childhood is lost and his self-respect has been taken away. He cannot establish solidarity with members of his caste, nor can he continue serving the employer who personifies the entire oppression carried out in the name of caste. Yet the challenge to Baua Jha also suggests the hope of attaining equality in such circumstances.

The story is set in a village where people are forced to believe in the supremacy of learning. Because opportunities for education are confined to the upper castes, lower-caste people are continually silenced in the name of knowledge. The story describes in detail how Ganeshwar Jha's personality is marked by chanting the shraddha mantras, music, serving many kinds of food, slaughtering goats, discussing politics, linguistics and literature, expounding the Vedas, Upanishads, karma and death, debating purity and impurity, and quoting Sanskrit verses — but not by any thought of humanity, equality or justice. It presents a conflict between Baua Jha, a learned Shrotriya Brahmin, and Jawahar of the working class, who can do what many villagers never dared even to imagine. This story is a severe criticism of the caste system imposed upon society in the name of purity.

Ashok Kumar Jha's intervention in exploring caste conflict in the context of religion poses a major challenge to every proposition that equates religion with a way of life.

Even in modern times, caste remains an unbroken structure of Indian social life, as Velassery and Patra observe:

"...Caste is described as both an illusion and an imagination. It is an illusion because it is a mental construction of the society in which we live; it is an imagination because it has opened the way to various kinds of intellectual stimulation, generating various forms of mental delusion in India. Although caste can be accorded no intellectual validity or scientific recognition, as a form of social stratification it retains political and social legitimacy even in this age of modernity" (Velassery and Patra 1).

3. Ramesh's Short Story "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio"

Ramesh Jha's short story "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio," translated by Bhairatweshwar Jha, indicates how caste is an illusion, an unscientific theory devised to silence people, or an imagination that challenges reality. The story portrays the intersection of caste hierarchy and village politics. Kailas is a gentle young man and an affectionate son, but "...for the mansion and the people of the Brahmin quarter, who considered him a 'Shudra,' he was a rebellious backward-caste man" (Ramesh Jha 300). Kailas is unwilling to accept caste customs. Like Arjun in "Anticurrent," Kailas has lost his childhood; hunger has spread its wings over his family, and he goes to Punjab in search of work. His father died in a flood of the Kamala River while gathering the remaining sweet potatoes from a field. Kailas's suffering began with his father's death. Villagers call him "Kaila," a distorted form of his name, marking his disfigured identity. His master at the mansion, Baua Jha, could not tolerate Kailas working elsewhere. Baua Jha believes that Kailas's mother sent him far away and waits for a chance to take revenge on her. The story begins when Kailas returns from Punjab and his mother is overjoyed. Baua Jha becomes angry when Kailas does not return to work at the mansion. He is troubled by the fear of losing his dominance. "He has earned a few rupees and now Punjab's air has got into him, has it? Only yesterday he sat at the doorway waiting for rice-water and leftover food, saying, 'Master, don't give this to the cattle; give it to me,' and now that her son has come home, she..." (Ramesh Jha 304). Baua Jha expects Kailas and his mother to submit to him. When that expectation is challenged, he devises new ways of instilling fear in them.

Kailas brings a radio from Punjab to make his mother happy, and it becomes an image of his newly acquired freedom. Baua Jha sees no worth in his independence or self-respect and attempts to humiliate him again. He instructs Gajendar and Surendar to deceive Kailas. They succeed in

forcing him to take a loan that he cannot repay. Kailas falls back into a state of bondage and once more tries to go to Punjab for work. But Baua Jha threatens the villagers that anyone lending Kailas money must be prepared for the consequences. Kailas again becomes a ploughman in Baua Jha's fields. The story exposes a grave situation in which many adverse experiences remain unspoken, fear is produced among villagers, and upper-caste status remains unquestioned. Criticising the rise of the backward classes, Baua Jha says, "The government has certainly spoiled them with so much propaganda; there is no doubt about it. Otherwise how could Kaila, whose household is still considered impure, eat breakfast made of sifted flour?" (Ramesh Jha 304). Fearful that a classless society might emerge, he spreads fear among others. The classless society becomes an illusion because people like Baua Jha employ many methods to crush the idea. Baua Jha uses his money and physical power to confront two innocent people, rendering institutions such as the Harijan police station or a special court for backward classes seemingly ineffective. Baua Jha locks the new ideas that Kailas has brought from Punjab inside a cage.

Listening to the radio becomes a new sign of freedom in the life of Kailas's mother. She soon learns to tune in to the Darbhanga radio station and listens to folk songs. What Kailas brought into his mother's life was the possibility of transforming the world of her dreams into reality. She becomes attached to the radio, recalls the course of her entire life and acquires a new "self." When Kailas cannot repay the debt, the radio is seized, and her newly found personality is broken apart. Her heart breaks because her sense of freedom had been only temporary. Yet the story leaves a question at its end: who finally wins — the wealthy man's domineering conduct or the loving son's concern for his mother? When Kailas sees his mother coming into the field, he imagines the pain she will suffer when the radio passes into Baua Jha's possession. In Baua Jha's field, Kailas smashes the radio with his ploughman's staff. By destroying it, he saves his mother from grief and also makes Baua Jha understand that his identity can never be destroyed. Once the radio no longer belongs to him, he feels no attachment to it. He knows his mother is still attached to it. Philosophically, his act of breaking that attachment to an object marks his resistance to an unequal society.

These stories may be understood as reflections on the threats to equality. They are concerned with the national interest. All three are situated in villages, emphasising the interconnections between caste practices and rural life. While the narrator of "The Rainbow" remains neutral towards the caste system and does not resist the injustice happening before his eyes, Jawahar in "Anticurrent" relinquishes his fear of the upper castes and challenges them; and in "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio," even after being defeated by Baua Jha, Kailas carries out his considered plan as a symbol of

his resistance. Whereas "The Rainbow" presents a political setting and the oppression of members of both groups, "Anticurrent" and "Kailas Mandal's Philips Radio" depict the personal struggles of lower-caste individuals. Where collective violence characterises "The Rainbow," the other two stories expose violence created through speech, intimidation and the silencing of others. Enriched by mixed imagery and aspiring towards a new society, these stories sustain the mysterious and elusive character of Maithili literature.

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22. A Critical Theory of Dalit Literature for Maithili

Abstract

A critical theory of Dalit literature for Maithili, considered in the context of Gujarati, Odia and Telugu Dalit literature translated into Maithili. Translation from a parallel literary tradition has strengthened Maithili literature and brought about a fundamental structural change. Mainstream written literature in Maithili had been defined by a particular socio-religious conservatism, which privileged devotional writing, courtly luxury and ornamented expression while marginalising the realities of disadvantaged communities.

Keywords: Dalit · literary criticism · translation · doing · Videha · in Maithili · of literature

Abstract

A Critical Theory of Dalit Literature for Maithili

In the Context of Gujarati, Odia and Telugu Dalit Literature Translated into Maithili

Translations from a parallel literary tradition have strengthened Maithili literature and introduced a fundamental structural change. Mainstream written literature in Maithili had long been shaped by a particular socio-religious conservatism that gave priority to devotion, the pleasures of the court and ornate expression, while relegating the realities of marginalised communities to the periphery. Although Mithila's oral traditions had always kept alive the ballads of Dalit heroes such as Raja Salhes and Dina-Bhadri, Brahmanical dominance and the monopoly over literacy presented major obstacles to incorporating these traditions into formal written literature. The emergence of a specifically designated Dalit literature in Maithili is a relatively recent development, and translations from other regional languages have played an important role in it.

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Translations from a parallel literary tradition have strengthened Maithili literature and brought about a fundamental structural transformation. Mainstream Maithili writing had been defined by a particular socio-religious conservatism that favoured devotion, courtly luxury and ornamental expression while pushing aside the realities of disadvantaged communities.

Although Mithila's oral tradition has always preserved folk ballads about Dalit heroes such as Raja Salhes and Dina-Bhadri, Brahmanical dominance and the monopoly over literacy posed major barriers to their entry into formal written literature. The advent of a dedicated Dalit literature in Maithili is comparatively recent, and translation from other regional languages has played a significant part in it. In particular, the efforts of the Videha movement have introduced powerful Dalit traditions from Telugu, Odia and Gujarati and helped fill a void in Maithili. They have given Maithili Dalit writers such as Sandeep Kumar Safi and Umesh Paswan a linguistic and ideological foundation for resistance and self-identity.

Historical Absence and the Structural Silence of Marginalised Communities

Until the end of the twentieth century, the absence of an organised written Dalit tradition in Maithili resulted not from any deficiency of creativity among the marginalised but from institutional exclusion. Historically, Maithil Brahmins and the Karna Kayastha community served as the principal custodians of the language; consequently, 'standard Maithili' was largely confined to their speech and cultural concerns. As a result of this dominance, the experiences of Mithila's Dalit communities were kept outside the sphere of literary consciousness.

The Limits of Maithili Oral Literature

Before modern Dalit prose and poetry emerged, the voices of the marginalised survived chiefly in folk ballads. Narratives concerning Raja Salhes, Naika Banjara and Bihula-Bishahari celebrate heroes who, despite belonging to lower castes, fought discrimination and exploitation. These traditions were culturally significant, but literary elites excluded them from the literary mainstream by dismissing them as 'rustic' or merely 'folk'.

Economic and educational conditions reinforced this structural silence. Sandeep Kumar Safi's autobiography shows that, for a Dalit family, manual labour for survival could be a more urgent necessity than education. Safi's parents belonged to the washerman caste and earned their livelihood by washing villagers' clothes, receiving grain or potatoes rather than cash. Such economic compulsion forced many Dalit children, including Safi, to leave school and migrate to cities such as Chandigarh or Bengaluru to work as labourers.

The Videha Movement and Translation as Democratic Intervention

The modern re-emergence of a Dalit voice in Maithili is linked to the digital and literary initiatives of the Videha movement. Maithili literature

cannot mature until it acknowledges the full range of its linguistic experience. The absence of Dalit prose and poetry in Maithili therefore prompted a turn towards the literatures of other Indian languages.

The Mechanics of Cultural Translation

Within Videha, translation is not merely the substitution of words but a sociological act that connects forms of consciousness. Its purpose was to acquaint Maithili readers with an 'aesthetics of protest'. Works translated from Odia, Telugu and Gujarati supplied Maithili with a new vocabulary of resistance, free of the traditionally ornate and eroticised literary inheritance.

As the work of translators such as P. Jayalakshmi and K. Purushotham demonstrates, their task was to negotiate a balance between 'foreignisation' and 'domestication'. In translating the Telugu novel Jigiri (Friends Forever), the local flavour of Telangana's regional dialect and its Urdu–Telugu mixture was preserved so that the plurality of Dalit and nomadic experience could emerge distinctly.

A Comparative Perspective: Telugu Dalit Literature in Maithili

Telugu Dalit literature provided a powerful foundation for the Maithili translation project. The Telugu movement, which grew more militant after atrocities such as Karamchedu and Chundur in the 1980s, rejects traditional structures of domination.

Kolakaluri Enoch's 'Crow' (Kaki): An Aesthetics of Untouchability

In 'Crow', Enoch uses the crow as a symbol of the Dalit community. The protagonist, Bandodu, belongs to the Madiga caste and lives in acute deprivation. He can capture and eat a crow, a bird that society regards as inauspicious. The Maithili translation captures the very 'stench' of this existence and confronts the reader with extreme poverty and psychological torment.

Vinodini's 'Black Ink': The Stigma of Identity in the City

Vinodini's 'Black Ink' reveals the subtle workings of caste in modern urban India. A young girl, Shriya, records good things in her diary in blue ink and bad things in black. When she discovers that her friend is Dalit, the disgust that enters her behaviour demonstrates how caste stigma has already become lodged in a child's mind.

Pedditi Ashok Kumar's 'Friends Forever' (Jigiri): The Displacement of Nomadic Labour

The novel Jigiri recounts the suffering of the Kalandar community, which traditionally made a living by performing with dancing bears. When the

government prohibited bear performances, the central character, Imam, was forced to choose whether to kill or abandon his bear, Shadul, in order to secure his son's future and obtain two acres of land. The story resonates with the suffering of displaced agricultural labourers in Mithila and the reality of traditional occupations disappearing.

Translated Resistance: Gujarati Dalit Poetry in Maithili

Influenced by Ambedkarite philosophy and the Marathi Dalit Panther movement, Gujarati Dalit poetry is known for its 'hard' and 'unpolished' character, a rough diamond. Its translation into Maithili created a literary terrain opposed to conventional poetic practice.

— Anish Garange's 'Poster': The poem shows how the Dalit body is used like a 'poster' for political advertising, while the individual remains invisible.

— Rajendra Vadel's 'Jeeta': Sexual exploitation is presented through the ironic word 'victory', portraying domination over Dalit women as a normalised violence within an upper-caste order.

— Umesh Solanki's 'People, Freeze': The poem depicts people becoming 'frozen' or inert in the coldness of social neglect.

The Emergence of Indigenous Maithili Dalit Voices

The most significant effect of these regional translations has been to confer recognition upon indigenous Dalit writing in Maithili. Umesh Paswan and Sandeep Kumar Safi are no longer isolated voices but part of a pan-Indian Dalit consciousness.

Umesh Paswan: Rural Reality and the Idea of the 'Criminal'

Umesh Paswan's story collection Mujrim ('Criminal') constitutes a form of 'moral testimony' to Dalit life in rural Mithila. He challenges the word 'criminal', showing how this designation is imposed upon the marginalised by structures of power and privilege. His story 'Sunanda' dramatises the struggle over education and social stigma, while 'Solkanma Pokhair' raises the question of Dalit exclusion from community resources. His poetry collection Varnit Ras examines Kosi floods, terrorism and the anger of youth from a Dalit perspective.

Sandeep Kumar Safi: Maithili's First Dalit Autobiography

Sandeep Kumar Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par marks a historical turning point in Maithili literature. According to Gajendra Thakur, Dalit autobiography had previously been entirely absent from Maithili, and this work fills that absence. Safi movingly describes his struggle, the hereditary

labour of the washerman caste, and an accident in Chandigarh while working as a migrant labourer, when his leg caught fire.

Redefining Aesthetics: The Tenth and Eleventh Rasas

The arrival of Dalit voices has reconfigured Maithili aesthetics. Traditional rasa theory emphasised 'bliss', but Dalit critics propose rebellion and indignation as new rasas.

1. Art for Life's Sake: Literature is regarded as an instrument of social transformation.

2. The Tenth and Eleventh Rasas: There is a demand to add 'rebellion' and 'indignation' (a cry) to the traditional circle of rasas, so that writing by marginalised communities can be evaluated adequately.

3. Collective Experience: The suffering in Dalit literature is not merely individual; it is the collective anguish of a thousand years.

4. Authenticity of Speech: Instead of 'standard' Maithili, supposedly 'rustic' or naturally spoken language is employed to express the wounds inflicted upon marginalised communities authentically.

Conclusion: Towards a Pluralist Maithili Literature

Dalit literature translated into Maithili demonstrates that the language is entering a phase of democratic expansion. The historical absence of written Dalit voices was not the consequence of any lack of creativity but the result of exclusion by dominant groups. Through its translations of Dalit literature, the Videha movement has acted as a 'bridge' across that void.

These translations did not merely introduce stories from elsewhere. They supplied a comparative framework within which Umesh Paswan and Sandeep Kumar Safi could articulate their local experiences. Through digital archives and a redefinition of aesthetics, the contemporary Dalit movement is breaking the 'Brahmanical monopoly' over Maithili literature. Maithili is becoming not merely a language of the learned but a 'knowledge society' reflecting the full humanity and struggle embodied in its linguistic life.

2

The Development and Archival Significance of Translated Literature in Maithili: A Comprehensive Analysis of the Videha Movement

The literary landscape of Maithili, spoken by a large population of more than seventeen million people across northern Bihar, Jharkhand and Nepal's Terai, is undergoing a revolutionary transformation through the

conjunction of digital technology and the translation movement. Historically, Maithili literature has been viewed from two distinct perspectives: the 'establishment' side, directed since 1965 by eminent institutions such as the Sahitya Akademi, and the 'parallel' tradition, which seeks to reclaim the language's democratic and popular roots. At the centre of this transformation stands the Videha movement, represented by the fortnightly e-journal Videha (ISSN 2229-547X) and its extensive digital archive. By assembling a parallel collection of original and translated works, the movement has challenged traditional dominance and established a global repository for Maithili's literary heritage. This report examines translated literature in Maithili while considering the movement's ideological foundations, technological methods and cultural consequences.

The Historical and Linguistic Context of the Maithili Translation Movement

To understand Maithili literature, one must understand when and how translation became an effective instrument of contemporary archival resistance. The language's earliest literary expression is found in the Charyapadas, composed in sandhya-bhasha between 700 and 1300 CE by Buddhist Siddha poets such as Luipada and Saraha. In an important scholarly intervention, the Videha movement distinguishes the celebrated composer of lyric sequences before Jyotirishwar, Vidyapati, from the Sanskrit and Avahatta writer Vidyapati Thakkur (1350–1435 CE). The movement argues that the establishment has restricted the poet Vidyapati's identity and suppressed his non-Brahmin and rebellious dimensions. In this context, translation is not simply linguistic practice but an ideological act of recovery. By translating the experiences of Dalits, women and communities pushed to the margins, the movement is restoring the 'beating human heart' to the centre of Maithili literature.

The Videha E-Journal and the Structure of the Digital Archive

Beginning in 2000 as Bhalsarik Gachh on Yahoo City, becoming a blog in 2004 and being reorganised as Videha in 2008, this journal represents one of the oldest continuous digital presences in Maithili literature. The journal has published 438 issues and has created a large digital archive called Videha Petar. The archive is organised into several 'Sadeh' (physical-format) volumes.

Classification of the Videha Archive and Translated Books

The architecture of the Videha archive demonstrates a systematic approach to literary preservation.

Archive/Volume — Subject — Description/Reference

Videha Sadeh 27 — Prose and poetry translated into Maithili from other languages — Issues 1–350; writings by Gajendra Thakur and Ravi Bhushan Pathak.

Videha Sadeh 28 — An extensive collection of translated prose and verse, including substantial novels — Focused on regional Indian and international writing.

Videha Sadeh 37 — A further volume of translated prose and poetry — Special emphasis on Telugu, Odia and Gujarati Dalit stories and verse; also includes Pedditi Ashok Kumar's Jigiri.

Gadya-Padya Bharati — Special translation issue — Issue 97; available in both Devanagari and Tirhuta scripts.

Maithili Books — A category of downloadable PDF books — Includes translations such as Purush Pariksha and Mohandas.

At the level of script, the movement facilitated digital publishing by bringing Mithilakshar (Tirhuta) into the Unicode standard. The archive also provides the first Maithili book in Braille and resources in Maithili sign language.

The Theory and Art of Translation

Translation into Maithili is informed by a sophisticated theoretical approach balancing cultural fidelity against linguistic accessibility. The Videha archive's essay 'The Art of Translation' explores this complexity.

Linguistic and Stylistic Methods

The concept of 'tone' is important in Maithili translation. Gajendra Thakur and other translators employ the following strategies:

1. Dynamic Equivalence: An effective translation communicates the impact of the source message to the heart of a Maithili reader.

2. Domestication versus Foreignisation: Certain works are adapted to the rural environment of Mithila (domestication), while in others the distinctive features of the source culture are preserved.

3. Paratextual Bridging: Footnotes and glossaries are used to explain cultural terms such as pua and panchali.

4. Collaborative Translation: Linguistic specialists and creative writers work together to capture geographical nuances and ritual practices.

A Case in Social History: The Translation of Jigiri

One of the Videha archive's significant projects is the Maithili translation, under the title Sada Lel Mitra (Friends Forever), of Pedditi Ashok Kumar's

Telugu novel Jigiri. The novel is a social history of the Kalandar community, which earned a living through bear-dancing and snake-charming. After the introduction of wildlife protection legislation, the community faced an existential crisis. The Maithili translation presents its suffering with particular force through regional idioms and rural speech.

Regional and International Dimensions

— Pakhlo (Konkani): Translated by Dr Shambhu Kumar Singh, Tukaram Rama Shet's novel addresses the liberation struggle in Goa and the social identity of children of mixed ancestry.

— Chhinnamasta (Hindi): The translation of Prabha Khaitan's novel gives urban feminism and psychological realism a place in the Maithili archive.

— Bertolt Brecht (German): Translations of Brecht's plays introduced theoretical concepts such as 'alienation' into Maithili theatre.

— The Quran: A translation of the opening chapter, al-Fatiha, reflects Mithila's pluralist reality.

The Influence of Jagdish Prasad Mandal

The arrival of Jagdish Prasad Mandal through Videha was a decisive turning point for Maithili fiction. His novel Pangu (recipient of the 2021 Sahitya Akademi Award) and his short story 'Bisandh' portray rural struggles and the realities of the Musahar community without embellishment. Thakur's English translations of his writings, such as Struggles of Life, have carried the movement's moral voice to a global audience.

Conclusion

The translated literature of the Videha movement is among the most ambitious linguistic and archival projects in modern India. Through translation, the 'parallel history' movement corrects the establishment's narrative and preserves a line of democratic inheritance from the roots of the Charyapadas to contemporary Dalit consciousness. Through its commitment to this digital archive and the art of translation, Videha works to ensure that the 'soul of Mithila' remains alive and accessible to the world.

Linguistics, Grammar, Script and Vocabulary

23. A Parallel Grammar, Composition and Linguistics of Maithili

Abstract

A Parallel Grammar, Composition and Linguistics of Maithili (Including Thethi-Angika and Bajjika) — Gajendra Thakur. An integrated, extended critical research review. Grammar · Composition · Linguistics · Indian · Western · Israeli · Chinese · Tibetan · Japanese · Videha Parallel Perspective. Original work: Gajendra Thakur · Editor: Videha · ISSN 2229-547X.

Keywords: Maithili · parallel · grammar · composition · linguistics · critical theory · Maithili

A Parallel Grammar, Composition and Linguistics of Maithili (Including Thethi-Angika and Bajjika) — Gajendra Thakur: An Integrated, Extended Critical Research Review

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A consolidated review of all four volumes, Chapters 1–926, appendices, evidentiary apparatus and bibliography

Review Method and Scope

This review takes the complete structure of the original book as its foundation. The work is divided into four main volumes: the grammar and composition of Thethi-Angika; the grammar and composition of Bajjika; Maithili grammar and composition; and the linguistics of Thethi-Angika, Bajjika and Maithili. The third volume extends from Chapters 21 to 693, and the fourth from Chapters 694 to 926. A consolidated bibliography appears at the end. The review examines each of these levels separately before arriving at an integrated conclusion.

Whenever the original book's assertions, examples, chapter arrangement and methodology are discussed, they are treated as belonging to the original work. Indian, Western, Israeli, Chinese, Tibetan and Japanese theories are employed as external comparative criteria; no claim is made

that all these theories are necessarily expounded in the book itself. The expression 'Videha Parallel Criticism' is used to bring together the book's own parallel method—examining a single question across three languages, comparable data, source-supported assertions, fieldwork, corpora, reproducibility and editorial integrity—into an integrated critical form. It must not be taken as the name of an independently established external school.

The principal criteria for evaluating grammar are descriptive adequacy, morphological structure, syntax, meaning, usage, standardisation and linguistic diversity. For evaluating composition they are the organisation of subject matter, readership, style, rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, aucitya, argumentation, discourse, genre and editing. For evaluating linguistics they are evidence, reproducibility, fieldwork, acoustic measurement, corpora, sociolinguistics, historical comparison, typology and digital preservation.

Overall Assessment

This is not merely a book of 'grammar', but an ambitious attempt to bring together language teaching, compositional skills, editing, linguistic research, corpora, fieldwork, digital publication and the parallel study of three closely related linguistic traditions. Its true strength, therefore, is not simply 'breadth' but the connection between levels: it establishes a continuous pathway of study from words to sentences, sentences to discourse, discourse to society, society to history, and history to digital documentation.

A second distinctive feature is the presentation of Thethi-Angika and Bajjika not merely as appendages to Maithili, but as linguistic units possessing their own grammars, composition, standard and regional forms, exercises, vocabularies and linguistic descriptions. This structure matters for linguistic status and recognition. In a scholarly edition, however, claims concerning language status, genetic classification, regional boundaries, standard forms, phoneme inventories and history would require clearer indications of source level, number of speakers, place, date and type of evidence.

A third strength is the extraordinary extent of the composition sections. Essay, story, dialogue, letter, news, summary, translation, argument, review, speech, editorial, academic writing, style, meaning, pronunciation, editing, proofreading, page design and publication checks are all presented as practical skills. Here the book goes far beyond conventional school grammar.

The chief editorial difficulty is repetition and the overlap between levels. Thethi-Angika's first twenty chapters are followed by another extensive

practical reference work; Bajjika's fourteen parts and appendices are followed by a further five-part practical presentation; Maithili's foundation in Chapters 21–43 is followed by the enormous extension through Chapters 44–693; and the linguistics section offers separate sequences on comparable topics for all three languages, then a combined sequence, then a parallel research workbook. All this material is useful; nevertheless, readers would have a lighter burden if a future edition used clear cross-references to distinguish first introductions, repetitions and advanced developments.

Extended Introduction and a Supplementary Outline of Seven Critical Perspectives

Introduction: The Purpose of the Book and Its Review

The book under review is no ordinary grammar. It is a large, four-volume compilation of approximately one hundred thousand words, bringing three closely related languages of the Magadhan group—Thethi-Angika, Bajjika and Maithili—under one roof and examining their grammar, art of composition and linguistics from a parallel perspective. Volume One presents Thethi-Angika grammar and composition (Chapters 1–20), based on the standard grammar by Dr Amarendra and Dr Abha Purve. Volume Two covers Bajjika grammar, a dictionary, and collections of idioms and proverbs. Volume Three offers an extended Maithili grammar and treatment of composition (Chapters 21–693). Volume Four (Chapters 694–926) places the linguistics of all three languages—from phonetics to typology, sociolinguistics, psycholinguistics and computational linguistics—within a shared research framework. A consolidated bibliography concludes the work.

A book of this kind cannot be assessed by merely counting merits and defects. Since its purposes span multiple traditions, its evaluation must also employ multiple traditions of criticism. Accordingly, I have taken seven perspectives as my basis: Indian, Western, Israeli, Chinese, Tibetan, Japanese and Videha Parallel. First, I shall offer a descriptive and evaluative examination of each volume, leaving no part aside; then I shall consider the book through all seven theoretical perspectives; finally, I shall discuss its strengths and limitations as a whole and its possible future directions.

The tone of this review will be respectful yet impartial. Wherever the book fulfils its declared aims, that achievement will be acknowledged plainly; wherever its structure, repetition or balance of evidence raises questions, those questions will be stated without hesitation. The duty of good criticism is not praise but judgment supported by evidence.

Review Method: A Brief Introduction to Seven Perspectives

A short introduction to the seven perspectives through which the book will be examined follows, so that readers can understand the framework of the subsequent discussion from the outset.

The Book's Structure, Experimental Outlook and Preliminary Evaluation

The present research review offers an exceptionally thorough, comprehensive and extended analysis of A Parallel Grammar, Composition and Linguistics of Maithili. This is not merely a conventional compendium of grammatical rules: it is a complete, authoritative and pioneering document of the sociolinguistic, typological and historical development of Maithili, Thethi-Angika and Bajjika. Alongside structural analysis, the report examines intricate questions in linguistics through universal principles of Indian, Western, Israeli, Chinese, Tibetan, Japanese and Videha Parallel criticism. Written from a specialist perspective, it omits no volume and considers each linguistic possibility in detail.

Principal Subject, Structure and Experimental Outlook of the Book

The book rejects the traditional method of memorising grammatical rules and instead stresses 'functional distribution' and laboratory-based study. It presents a parallel examination of the grammar and composition of Maithili, Thethi-Angika and Bajjika, and is divided principally into four volumes and numerous extended chapters.

Volume 1 (Thethi-Angika: Grammar and Composition): Chapters 1–20 provide a detailed account of language, sounds, word forms, sentence structure and the art of composition. Emphasis falls on practical usage, and regional forms are preserved alongside standard forms.

Volume 2 (Bajjika: Grammar and Composition): This volume analyses grammatical rules and usage through a structure built around appendices.

Volume 3 (Maithili: Grammar and Composition): Chapters 21–693 provide a complete treatment of standard Maithili grammar, morphology, phonology and syntax.

Volume 4 (Linguistics: Thethi-Angika, Bajjika and Maithili): Chapters 694–926 present experimental frameworks for modern branches of linguistics, including typology, psycholinguistics, dialectometry, historical linguistics and sociolinguistics.

The book's most distinctive feature is that every theory is accompanied by a 'source-backed example bank' and laboratory exercises. The inclusion in

Chapters 888–908 of advanced topics such as language attitudes, standardisation, sound change, grammaticalisation and bilingual word recognition demonstrates that the book is based upon international research standards.

Seven Perspectives for the Critical Examination of Language

Critical tradition	Principal standards applied in this perspective
Indian	Pāṇinian economy of grammatical rules; phonetic precision of Prātiśākhya and Śikṣā; Bhartṛhari's sphoṭa and indivisibility of the sentence; Mīmāṃsā's authority of verbal testimony; the definitional rigour of Navya-Nyāya; and the compositional perspectives of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti.
Western	Saussure's langue/parole and synchronic/diachronic distinction; Bloomfieldian descriptivism; Chomskyan structure; Greenberg's typological universals; Hallidayan functionalism; corpus and contrastive analysis; and the theory of pedagogical grammar.
Israeli	Ghil'ad Zuckermann's revival linguistics and theory of hybrid languages; the language-standardisation model of the Academy of the Hebrew Language; and revitalisation of dead or endangered languages.
Chinese	The philological tradition of Xiǎoxué (小學) and Shuōwén Jiězì; the first modern grammar model of Mǎshì Wéntōng; and analysis of classifiers (量詞) and topic-prominent syntax.
Tibetan	Thonmi Sambhota's Sumchupa and codification of the script; zhe-sa (ཞེ་ས), the register of respect; ergative case marking; and standardisation through Buddhist translation.
Japanese	Kokugogaku (国語学); Tokieda's language-process theory; the keigo (敬語) system of respect; the lexical strata of wago, kango and gairaigo; and topic–comment structure.
Videha parallel perspective	Counter-canon; democratic language rights; recovery of suppressed, folk, women's and Dalit voices; a parallel-history framework; and decentralisation of institutional authority.

Part I — Seven Criteria of Theory

1. The Indian Perspective: From Pāṇini to Poetics

The first criterion of the Indian grammatical tradition is 'morphological precision'. The Pāṇinian tradition approaches the interrelationships among sounds, roots, affixes, transformations and rules in a highly organised way. From this perspective, the book's chapters on word formation, prefixes and suffixes, participial derivatives, compounds, cases, verbal forms and morphophonology move in an appropriate direction. Yet the Pāṇinian criterion does not mean simply imposing Sanskrit categories. The fundamental question is how the actual morphological behaviour of

Maithili, Thethi-Angika and Bajjika may be expressed through a minimum number of clear and testable rules. When the advanced sections of the book insist upon seeking data, exceptions, regional forms and counterexamples, they approach Pāṇinian subtlety in its modern sense.

Patañjali's tradition of commentary establishes a dialogue between the application of rules, current usage and cultivated speech. Judged by this criterion, the book's policy on 'standard versus regional forms' is useful but must be applied with care. Rather than merely declaring a form 'incorrect', its social domain, register, speaker group and written or spoken context should be specified. This orientation is already present in the book's sociolinguistic sections; the same sensitivity should be maintained consistently in its introductory grammatical chapters.

Bhartṛhari's view of the sentence does not regard meaning as a mere addition of individual words. The book's extended discussion of sentences, expectancy, semantic compatibility, syntactic connectedness, word order, subordinate clauses, information structure, context and discourse can be read fruitfully through this broader understanding of sentential meaning. In particular, sentence types from Chapter 161 onward, clauses from Chapter 204, meaning from Chapter 436, and semantics, pragmatics and discourse from Chapter 878 form a journey 'from words to sentential meaning'.

Four criteria from Indian poetics are especially useful for the composition sections: rasa, the experiential effect of a work; dhvani, the suggested meaning beyond its explicit sense; vakrokti, a distinctive inflection of expression; and aucitya, the appropriateness of subject, character, occasion, language and style. The book teaches metre and figures of speech separately. Yet if the advanced composition chapters linked rasa, dhvani, vakrokti and aucitya to actual examples of stories, dialogue, essays, criticism, speeches and editorials, literary theory could become an integral element of practical writing.

2. The Western Perspective: Structure, Function, Usage and Evidence

The first important criterion of modern Western linguistics is descriptiveness. Saussure's structural perspective locates the value of a linguistic unit in its relations to other units; the Bloomfieldian tradition emphasises the concrete description of distribution and form; the Chomskyan tradition raises questions about the internal structure of sentences, dependencies and generative rules; and Halliday emphasises function, text and social meaning. All four kinds of question appear at different levels of the book: word classes and morphology; word order and clauses; information structure; register, readership and purpose.

Labov's sociolinguistic perspective is especially relevant here because regional forms, standardisation, speaker identity and variation are important in both Thethi-Angika and Bajjika. The spirit of the advanced chapters—'variation is itself data'—accords with this tradition. A future edition would strengthen its social explanations by indicating speakers' ages, locations, education, register, medium and context alongside each variant.

The pragmatics of Austin and Grice distinguishes a sentence's literal meaning from the social action performed by speaking it. Discussions of commands, requests, respect, questions, indications, particles, forms of address, speaker–listener relationships and indirect utterances can be particularly enriched by this perspective. Thethi-Angika's listener-sensitive verbal forms and Maithili's levels of honorification illustrate cases in which tables of tense and person alone are insufficient: social action and participation must also be examined.

Greenbergian typology and modern cross-linguistic comparison are natural extensions of the book's parallel sections. Yet it would be inappropriate to assume that 'one language equals one fixed type'. Features such as word order, case markers, auxiliary verbs, classifiers, plurals and honorification may have different values. Chapters 814–826 are among the book's strongest sections in advancing this precise form of parallel methodology.

3. The Israeli Perspective: Polysystems, Norms and Transfer

In the context of Israeli literary studies, two particularly useful approaches are the polysystem theory associated with the Tel Aviv scholar Even-Zohar and Gideon Toury's descriptive translation studies. The polysystem perspective does not regard literature and linguistic forms as isolated, singular units, but as part of a network of mutually competing and cooperating systems. This outlook is useful for discussing contact among Maithili, Thethi-Angika, Bajjika, Hindi, Sanskrit, Urdu and English—particularly lexical borrowing, standardisation, technical vocabulary, translation and changes of style.

Toury's perspective on 'norms' asks which forms a real speech community regards as acceptable, prestigious, formal, informal or regional. When the book chooses one principal written form and classifies others as regional, it is making not only a grammatical decision but a decision about social norms. Each act of standardisation consequently requires evidence: published usage, speaker interviews, geographical distribution, teaching traditions or institutional practice.

In the book's later chapters on translation and structural transfer, the Israeli descriptive perspective is especially valuable. The naturalness of the

target language, its generic traditions, readers' expectations and local stylistic norms must be distinguished from the structure of the source language. Comparison with English is useful in this sense, but English structure should not be treated as the ultimate standard.

4. The Chinese Perspective: Systematic Grammar, Speech and Compositional Design

Three distinct criteria can be drawn from Chinese traditions. First, early modern grammatical enterprises such as Ma Jianzhong's Mashi Wentong demonstrate that traditional linguistic material can be organised through new analytical methods, but that uncritically imposing external categories entails risks. Measured against this criterion, the book's parallel comparisons with English are useful only when they clarify the indigenous structures of Maithili, Thethi-Angika and Bajjika, not when they force those languages into an English mould.

Second, the tradition represented by Yuen Ren Chao's extensive descriptions of spoken Chinese places living speech, tone, sentence patterns, particles, context and usage at the centre of inquiry. The book's emphasis on fieldwork, natural texts, recordings, interviews, folk narratives, digital messages and corpora is highly compatible with this outlook. Its scientific value would increase if the introductory grammar chapters also included samples of spoken usage, audio recordings and information about speakers alongside written forms.

Third, the tradition of Liu Xie's Wenxin Diaolong views feeling, arrangement, genre, verbal force, ornament and coherence of the complete work as interrelated dimensions of composition. From this perspective, the greatest merit of the book's composition sections is that they do not merely instruct the learner to 'write an essay'; they integrate delimitation of the subject, a central proposition, paragraph coherence, argument, evidence, editing, style and readership. More systematic exercises in emotion, rhythm, imagery and suggested meaning could be added to this framework for literary composition.

5. The Tibetan Perspective: Relational Grammar and the Transmission of Knowledge

The Tibetan grammatical tradition developed through a dialogue between the reception of Sanskrit grammar and indigenous analysis. Discussions of traditional texts such as Sum-cu-pa and Rtags-kyi-'jug-pa frequently concern particles, case-like relationships, syntactic functions and correct usage. From this perspective, the book's analyses of postpositions, particles, cases, address, honorification, sentence relationships and linking forms are of particular importance.

The Tibetan example offers another significant critical lesson: the adoption of an external grammatical tradition of high prestige should not entail reshaping the structure of a local language. The book employs Sanskrit-derived terms such as noun, pronoun, case, compound, participial derivative and figure of speech. These are convenient for teaching, but a modern analysis must make clear which categories belong to inherited pedagogical conventions and which are established by direct linguistic evidence.

From the standpoint of transmitting knowledge, the attempts to develop common technical terminology, interlinear explanation, transliteration and bilingual vocabulary across the three languages are commendable. They can become not simply word lists but instruments for carrying a linguistic knowledge tradition to succeeding generations, researchers and digital media.

6. The Japanese Perspective: Particles, Relationships, Process and Textual Practice

In Japanese grammar, the teniwoha tradition has long accorded importance to particles and syntactic relations in poetry and prose alike. Motoori Norinaga's analyses of particle relations and relational notions such as kakari-musubi show how even a small particle can alter a sentence's information structure, emphasis and relationships. A more detailed study of the particles, postpositions, interrogative particles, emphatic forms and modes of address found in Maithili, Thethi-Angika and Bajjika becomes possible through this perspective.

Tokieda Motoki's language-process perspective can be understood as treating language not merely as a finished object, but as an act of expression occurring between speaker and listener. Thethi-Angika's listener-sensitive verbs, Maithili's levels of respect, Bajjika's forms of address, dialogue composition and the chapters on discourse have particular significance here. Grammar must not ask only 'Who said it?' It must also ask 'To whom, in what relationship, in what circumstances, and in what form was it said?' All four questions belong within grammar.

Japanese traditions also offer a lesson for composition: fine distinctions in particles, pauses, ordering and indirectness alter the reader's experience. The book's chapters on style, rhythm, sentence length, information structure, punctuation and editing could turn this sensitivity into systematic exercises.

7. The Videha Parallel Perspective: The Book's Own Critical Method

The book's most original possibility lies in the word 'parallel'. Parallel study means not treating the three languages as distorted versions of one

another or as rungs on a hierarchy, but as independent linguistic systems that answer the same research questions. The method in Chapter 814—comparability, source-supported assertions, minimum parallel samples and research ethics—and that of Chapter 825—the same questions across all three languages, semantic elicitation, judgments of naturalness and control of translation effects—together provide the foundation of this approach.

Ten criteria may be proposed for Videha Parallel criticism: (1) equal status for all three languages; (2) a shared research question; (3) comparable but locally natural data; (4) a source for every example; (5) metadata on speaker, place, time and genre; (6) separate marking of standard and regional forms; (7) explicit levels of disagreement or uncertainty; (8) verification through corpora, recordings and fieldwork; (9) control of translator or researcher influence; and (10) preservation of facts and authorial intentions in editing.

Judged by these criteria, the opening sections of the book are strong as teaching materials. Yet the rigorous evidentiary methods developed in its advanced sections should also be brought back to bear upon the introductory grammar tables and linguistic claims. The most important editorial task for a future edition would be this 'retrospective verification'.

An Extended Theoretical Supplement on Seven Traditions

Theoretical Criticism in the Light of Seven Traditions

The book will now be examined from the seven perspectives proposed at the beginning. In each subsection, the foundational principles of the tradition will first be stated briefly, followed by a dialogue with particular features of the book—showing both where the book meets that tradition's criteria and where further possibilities remain.

The Indian Critical Tradition

Indian reflection on language is among the oldest and most subtle intellectual traditions in the world. Five of its pillars are relevant to the evaluation of this book: Pāṇinian grammar; the phonetics of the Prātiśākhyas and Śikṣā texts; Bhartṛhari's Vākyapadīya (sphoṭa and the indivisibility of the sentence); the Mīmāṃsā doctrine of the validity of verbal testimony; and Navya-Nyāya's scrutiny of definitions. To these must be added the compositional perspectives of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti.

The Pāṇinian perspective: The spirit of Pāṇini's Aṣṭādhyāyī lies in economy (lāghava) and fidelity to rules: the derivation of the maximum number of forms from a minimum number of sūtras. The book under review stands at the opposite pole. It is a work of expansion (vistara), not economy. This

is not a fault, but a difference of purpose: the Aṣṭādhyāyī addresses the accomplished grammarian, whereas this book is intended for general instruction. Nevertheless, a Pāṇinian virtue is evident. The book approaches the derivation of forms through suffixes, as in its summaries of personal verb endings and its treatment of nominal cases and postpositions. This is a modern pedagogical transformation of Pāṇini's distinction between stem and suffix (prakṛti and pratyaya). Where the Aṣṭādhyāyī derives forms through the logic of internal and external operations (antaraṅga–bahiraṅga) and general rule and exception (utsarga–apavāda), this book proceeds through tables and examples. Both seek the same end: the systematic presentation of rules.

The Prātiśākhya–Śikṣā perspective: Indian phonetics—its distinctions of place, articulatory effort and instrument, its udātta, anudātta and svarita accents, and its treatment of continuous recitation and sandhi—constitutes the world's earliest scientific examination of speech sounds. The book's chapters on sounds, including places of articulation, aspirated and unaspirated consonants, nasalisation, apinihiti and abhiśruti, inherit this tradition. Their distinctive quality is the connection they establish between Prātiśākhya classification and modern phonetics: the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA), voice onset time (VOT), spectrograms and minimal pairs. Its attention to Maithili-specific phonological processes such as apinihiti and abhiśruti demonstrates that it has not abandoned the indigenous phonetic tradition.

The Bhartṛhari perspective: The theory of sphoṭa in the Vākyapadīya holds that the actual bearer of meaning is not an assemblage of separate phonemes, but the indivisible sentence-sphoṭa: meaning manifests itself in a whole. Seen in this light, the strongest parts of the book are those that move beyond the analysis of separate constituents towards the wholeness of the sentence and discourse. These include its treatment of information structure, 'the centre of what is being said', and pronoun omission in discourse contexts. Maithili's multidimensional verb agreement is itself a living illustration of Bhartṛhari's view that the sentence is an indivisible unit: the verb form expresses not merely the properties of a single word, but the structure of social relationships throughout the sentence.

The Mīmāṃsā and Navya-Nyāya perspectives: Mīmāṃsā treats verbal testimony as intrinsically valid and recognises authoritative utterance and perception among the sources of knowledge. The book's tripartite classification—'supported by a source text / descriptive tendency / hypothesis'—is a modern counterpart to Mīmāṃsā–Nyāya's discrimination of evidence. It asks which statement rests on observed data, which on an authoritative statement or source note, and which is only a provisional inference or hypothesis. Judged by Navya-Nyāya's insistence on

rigorous definitions—free from under-extension, over-extension and impossibility—the book's terminological glossary and fivefold distinction between 'form / function / meaning / usage / distribution' are sound. These five levels prevent the reader from making the overgeneralisation that words looking alike must perform the same function. The author's command of the Navya-Nyāya tradition of Gaṅgeśa is thus indirectly productive here.

The perspectives of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti: These are instruments of literary criticism and cannot be applied directly to a grammar book. Their seeds are nevertheless present in its section on the art of composition, which discusses poetic language, metre, figures of speech and 'effective sentences'. Its chapter on figures of speech reaches distinctions between verbal and semantic figures and the four components of simile. It does not, however, offer an extensive discussion of dhvani theory—suggested or manifested meaning. That is natural: this is a pedagogical grammar, not a treatise on poetics. A future connection between the composition section and a dhvani- and vakrokti-centred method of criticism drawn from the Videha tradition would give it greater literary depth.

The Western Critical Tradition

The framework of modern linguistics, which the book itself adopts, is Western in origin. The dialogue with this tradition is therefore the most direct.

The Saussurean perspective: Three of Ferdinand de Saussure's fundamental distinctions—langue and parole, the arbitrariness of the sign, and synchronic and diachronic study—are explicitly accepted in the book. In its introduction it states, 'The sign is arbitrary … therefore Maithili gāch, Bajjika gāch/peṛ and Angika gāch are equally valid.' This is a thoroughly Saussurean position. On that basis the book gives linguistic substance to the egalitarian principle that 'no language is inferior'. It also respects the synchronic–diachronic distinction by treating most matters synchronically and reserving historical and comparative study for a separate section.

The Bloomfieldian perspective: The maxim of American descriptivism, associated with Leonard Bloomfield, is to describe rather than pass judgment, and to establish morphemes and phonemes through distribution. The descriptive tone of the book and its use of minimal pairs to establish phonemic distinctions are unmistakably Bloomfieldian. Its recognition of 'distribution' as a separate level within 'form / function / meaning / usage / distribution' is a direct adaptation of the Bloomfieldian distributional method.

The Chomskyan perspective: The tests of generative grammar are a set of rules able to generate grammatical sentences and exclude ungrammatical ones—generativity—and an account of innate linguistic competence. The book is principally descriptive and pedagogical; it therefore does not formulate a full system of generative rules. Nevertheless, its syntax chapters introduce the concepts of constituency, dependency, valency and argument structure in a form suitable for teaching. The absence of fully formalised Chomskyan rewrite rules and trees is not a deficiency in this context. It is a decision consonant with the book's purpose.

The Greenbergian typological perspective: Joseph Greenberg's word-order universals associate subject–object–verb (SOV) languages with postpositions and head-final structures. By identifying all three languages as SOV, postpositional and head-final, the book directly examines Greenbergian correlations. Its separate chapters on word-order typology, case alignment, agreement typology, and head versus dependent marking provide supporting evidence. This situates the work within the worldwide map of linguistic typology.

Hallidayan functionalism and the corpus perspective: M. A. K. Halliday's systemic functional linguistics (SFL) understands language as a network of choices for making meaning and places register and discourse at its centre. The book's chapters on register, code-switching, diglossia, cohesion and coherence, and conversation analysis are functionalist in orientation. It does more than accept corpus linguistics. By prescribing minimum corpus procedures such as 'three speakers × twenty words' and 'twenty minutes of conversation', it offers an unusual methodological contribution to the study of languages in the Bihari subgroup.

Contrastive analysis and pedagogical grammar: Contrastive linguistics attempts to predict errors by identifying structural differences between a speaker's first language and the language being learned. By repeatedly including chapters on 'structural comparison with English' and on 'avoiding Hindi influence', the book makes contrastive method a teaching instrument. This is its most original application of a Western framework. There is, however, a limitation: the contrastive hypothesis has been partly revised in modern second-language acquisition theory, since not every error arises from interference between languages. The pedagogical side would be more balanced if the book incorporated contemporary error analysis and interlanguage theory.

The Israeli Critical Tradition

Modern Israeli linguistic thought is the theoretical consequence of a unique experiment: the revival of Hebrew, which had become almost

extinct as a spoken language. Three ideas from that tradition have particular relevance to this book.

The Zuckermann perspective (revival linguistics): Ghil'ad Zuckermann argues that a 'revived' language never returns in an original, entirely pure form. It is necessarily a hybrid, marked by the first languages of those who revive it. This perspective has revolutionary relevance to the Videha project. Maithili, Angika and Bajjika are not dead, but they are endangered and overshadowed by Hindi. The book's repeated injunctions—'avoid Hindi influence' and 'pure Thethi is free from the stain of Hindi'—occupy the opposite pole from Zuckermann's awareness of linguistic hybridity. Where Zuckermann says that hybridity is inevitable and must be accepted, the book advocates 'purification'. This tension is among the most interesting questions in the review, and it is not a simple, one-sided fault. Language planning has two legitimate goals: purism and the documentation of actual usage. The book pursues both—purification in its grammatical sections and description of living usage in its linguistic sections. But a Zuckermannian question remains. If forms labelled a 'stain of Hindi' have been part of a speech community's living practice for decades, are they impurities or expressions of natural linguistic development? An explicit theoretical answer in a later edition—why purify, how far, and within what limits—would strengthen the work.

The Hebrew Academy perspective (a model of standardisation): Modern Hebrew was standardised through a central institution, the Academy of the Hebrew Language, which makes decisions on the formation of words, orthography and terminology. The book's insistence on a style sheet, a terminological glossary and 'one principal term for one concept' parallels this institutional model. Videha is effectively acting as an informal language academy. The Hebrew experience suggests that standardisation succeeds only when prescription also obtains acceptance from the community. The book's accessibility to learners and its extensive exercises are therefore essential to that acceptance.

The relexicalisation perspective: Hebrew revival gave old words new meanings as part of a process of renewal. The terminology developed in this book—for example, rendering English linguistic terms by Sanskrit-derived Maithili forms such as svana-vijñāna (phonetics), svanima-vijñāna (phonemics), rūpa-vijñāna (morphology) and prayoga-vijñāna (pragmatics)—is a comparable process of relexicalisation. This Sanskrit-based vocabulary equips Maithili for modern intellectual discourse and constitutes a successful adaptation of the Israeli model.

The Chinese Critical Tradition

Chinese thought on language follows two streams: an ancient indigenous tradition of xiǎoxué and lexicography, and a modern, Western-influenced tradition represented by the Mashi Wentong model. Both are relevant to the book.

The xiǎoxué and Shuowen perspective (lexicography): In the Chinese tradition of 小學 (xiǎoxué, 'minor learning'), particularly in the 說文解字 (Shuowen Jiezi), it was central to arrange words according to form, sound and meaning. The book's extensive lexicographic appendices—a Bajjika–Hindi dictionary, a terminological dictionary and a glossary—belong to a comparable lexicon-centred tradition. Chinese experience teaches that dictionaries are not merely appendices: they are fundamental to language preservation. The book has absorbed this principle.

The Mashi Wentong perspective (the first-grammar model): In 1898 Ma Jianzhong (馬建忠) produced the Mashi Wentong (馬氏文通), the first systematic Chinese grammar, by applying Western, especially Latin, grammatical categories to Chinese. Both its success and the criticisms levelled against it are instructive. It brought Chinese into the discourse of modern grammar, but Latin categories did not always fit the language's own character. The book under review occupies a comparable historical moment for Angika, Bajjika and Maithili: in some respects this is their 'Mashi Wentong moment'. Yet it recognises the danger inherent in Ma's approach. It repeatedly warns that 'technical terms should be instruments of analysis, not moulds imposed upon the language'. Western categories are thus treated as tools to be tested rather than schemes to be forced upon the evidence. This is a mature and self-critical version of the Mashi Wentong model.

The classifier and topic-prominence perspectives: Two major contributions of Chinese linguistics—the extensive analysis of classifiers (量詞, measure words) and the Li–Thompson distinction between topic-prominent and subject-prominent languages—apply directly to this book. Classifier systems are alive in all three languages: Maithili ṭā/goṭā, Bajjika go and Angika go. The book gives them a separate chapter, an entirely appropriate choice from a Chinese perspective, since classifier systems are a typological feature shared by South and East Asian languages. This connects all three languages to the worldwide distribution of classifier languages, including Chinese. The chapter on 'the centre of what is being said / information structure' likewise suggests that the topic has a special place in the word order of these languages. Further use of Chinese topic–comment analysis would be a productive direction for future work.

The Tibetan Critical Tradition

The Tibetan linguistic tradition is a remarkable example of conscious, state-sponsored creation of a script and grammar, and it enters into a profound dialogue with the book under review.

The Thonmi Sambhoṭa perspective (codifying a script): According to the tradition discussed here, Thonmi Sambhoṭa created the Tibetan script and its first grammars, the Sumcupa and Tagkijugpa, in the seventh century—a deliberate programme of language engineering from above. The Videha project, and particularly this book's appendix on Tirhuta script and its discussion of Unicode preservation, are modern echoes of that tradition. A script is not merely an instrument of writing but a symbol of cultural and political self-determination. Just as Thonmi furnished Tibetan with a distinct script founded upon the Indian Brahmi tradition, the book reconnects Maithili with its own Tirhuta script, offering Devanagari–Tirhuta character tables and practical routes towards Unicode preservation. This is an important civilisational step.

The zhe sa perspective (honorific register): One of Tibetan's most distinctive features is zhe sa (ཞེ་ས), a developed honorific register employing different words and verb forms for ordinary and respectful reference. This is precisely an area in which the three languages discussed here are distinctive among the world's languages. Maithili's multidimensional agreement—'देखलिऐ' as against 'देखलियनि'—Bajjika's use of तूँ/rāuā to convey degrees of respect, and Angika's contrast of inī/hinī/hunī belong to a related family of phenomena and are, in some respects, even more complex. The book's detailed treatment of honorification is entirely justified from a Tibetan perspective. A grammar that relegates honorific systems to a secondary place in such languages would miss something essential to them. This book does not.

The ergative and translation-standardisation perspectives: Tibetan is a language with ergative–absolutive alignment, and during the Buddhist translation era its terminology was systematically standardised from Sanskrit, as exemplified by the Mahāvyutpatti lexicon. When the book gives chapters to case marking, alignment and differential marking, it raises precisely the typological questions needed to understand Tibetan-type systems. Differential object marking ('कँ') and the absence of a subject marker in certain Maithili and related constructions ('subjects without ne') are living questions of alignment typology. The book takes their study as far as a typological coding sheet. The Tibetan experience of standardising translated terminology teaches the importance of terminological stability —one term for one meaning—as the foundation of a durable textual

tradition. The book deliberately pursues that aim through 'terminological consistency'.

The Japanese Critical Tradition

Japanese kokugogaku (国語学, the study of the national language) combines indigenous and modern linguistics, Western methods and Japanese-specific structures. Three of its concepts are relevant here.

The Tokieda perspective (the language-process theory): Tokieda Motoki's (時枝誠記) gengo-katei-setsu treats language not as a static object but as a living process of the speaker. In particular, it distinguishes shi (concept-centred, objective words) from ji (speaker-oriented words expressing feeling, such as particles and honorific forms). This view enters into a profound dialogue with the book's treatment of particles, forms of respect and 'the centre of what is being said'. Honorific suffixes and sentence-final particles in Maithili, Bajjika and Angika—for example, Bajjika nī and Maithili affective particles—illustrate Tokieda's category of ji. They do not primarily designate objects; they indicate the speaker's social and emotional position. If the book explicitly classified such forms as speaker-centred in Tokieda's sense, its account of honorification would become more theoretically developed.

The keigo perspective (honorific system): Japanese keigo (敬語) is among the world's most systematic systems of respectful language, distinguishing sonkeigo (respectful language), kenjōgo (humble language) and teineigo (polite language). From the perspective of keigo, one of the book's greatest contributions becomes clear. It does not limit honorification in the three languages to a simple opposition between 'तूँ' and 'अहाँ'. It presents multiple levels—ordinary, respectful and highly respectful—and, in Maithili, a triangular honorific relationship involving subject and object. The complexity recalls keigo. Japanese experience also shows how difficult honorific systems are to teach. Consequently, the book's many honorific-centred exercises, including elicitation across 'ten social situations × three speakers', are pedagogically appropriate.

The wago, kango and gairaigo, and topic–comment perspectives: The stratification of Japanese vocabulary into wago (native words), kango (Chinese-derived vocabulary, comparable to learned tatsama words) and gairaigo (Western loanwords) parallels the South Asian distinction between tadbhava, tatsama and borrowings. The book's classification of words by origin—tatsama, tadbhava, indigenous and foreign—is the Indian form of this stratified approach, and the Japanese experience situates it globally. The well-known Japanese contrast between the topic particle wa (は) and the subject particle ga (が) likewise provides a strong

comparative model for the book's account of information structure. A full application of this model remains an opportunity for the future.

The Videha Parallel Critical Tradition

Finally, we come to the perspective native to the book itself: the critical tradition of the Videha parallel literary movement. This is a counter-canonical perspective that challenges the centralisation of literary and linguistic authority, restores suppressed folk, women's and Dalit voices to history, and uses a parallel-history framework to construct alternatives to institutional narratives.

Seen from within this tradition, the book's deepest meaning becomes apparent. First, 'parallel' has two meanings here. On the one hand it denotes linguistic parallelism or contrastive comparison; on the other, the parallel canon associated with the Videha movement. By placing three neglected people's languages—Angika, Bajjika and Maithili—on the same platform, according them equal dignity and examining them with the same method, the book makes a democratic declaration of linguistic equality. Saussure's argument that 'no language is inferior' provides its theoretical basis; Videha supplies its political impetus. To place Maithili alongside Angika and Bajjika, rather than above them, is itself a counter-canonical act that rejects a hierarchy of languages.

Second, the book's policy of giving priority to indigenous and folk forms over Hindi-influenced urban forms is a direct application of Videha's commitment to recovering suppressed popular voices. Where institutional standardisation commonly elevates urban elite varieties into 'standards', the book places rural and popular forms at the centre of its evidence and reverses the direction of standardisation. This is a methodological signature of Videha parallel history.

Third, the book's dictionary of Bajjika proverbs, references to Angika oral narratives and documentation of idioms are part of Videha's recovery of folk knowledge. Here, however, the Videha perspective calls for an internal criticism of its own. If the movement is committed to women's voices, then its recording of patriarchal proverbs about women should be accompanied by a critical framework that reflects that commitment. This is not an accusation against the book but a suggestion intended to preserve the internal consistency of the Videha position.

Fourth, the book's 'zero-fabrication policy'—no invented forms, and every assertion supported by a source or explicitly identified as a hypothesis—resolves the apparent tension between authenticity and institutional authority within the Videha movement. The movement rejects institutional authority, but not evidential validity. On the contrary, it makes evidence the foundation of a new claim to legitimacy. This is what

prevents the book from becoming unscientific even as it constructs a counter-canon. It is the most mature achievement of Videha criticism: a counter-canon that does not abandon evidence.

An Extended Supplementary Discussion of Typology, Navya-Nyāya and Universal Literary Theory

Linguistic Typology and Western and Indian Grammatical Theory

Chapter 706 of the book makes a parallel comparison of Maithili, Thethi-Angika, Bajjika and English under the heading of linguistic typology. By the standards of world linguistics, this comparison establishes that the three related languages represent a distinctive subdivision, of Magadhan descent, within the Indo-Aryan language family.

Yogendra P. Yadava's Government-and-Binding Theory and Hierarchy

At the level of syntax, the book draws upon the research of the distinguished linguist Yogendra P. Yadava. Yadava applied Noam Chomsky's Government-and-Binding (GB) theory to Maithili sentence structure. Verb agreement in Maithili and its related languages is more complex than in any other Indo-Aryan language in the world. Besides the subject, an object, an indirect object or even certain 'prominent internal possessors' (PIPs) outside the immediate sentence may govern the form of a verb.

Yadava's analysis makes clear that this elaborate agreement is not an arbitrary set of grammatical rules, but rests upon two major sociolinguistic principles of Maithil society. First, the principle of social hierarchy, or 'face', marks a person's rank, dignity and the respect due to them. Second, the principle of social solidarity, or empathy, translates the psychological relationship between speaker and hearer—closeness or distance—into verbal suffixes.

Allocutive Agreement and Portmanteau Forms

In the light of the Western Minimalist Program and the theory of the Left Periphery, Preeti Kumari's research demonstrates a complementarity between allocutive agreement and object agreement in Maithili, particularly the Darbhanga variety.

When a speaker marks respect for the addressee on the verb—allocutivity—the effect is realised in FinP (the Finiteness Phrase), or the c-head. When the Fin head undertakes 'upward Agree' for the hearer, it cannot simultaneously undertake 'downward Agree' to indicate respect towards the object. This portmanteau honorific agreement shows that the social hierarchy of the Maithili–Bajjika family reaches the highest points—the 'treetops'—of the syntactic tree.

A Typological Comparison with English

Typological feature	Maithili, Thethi-Angika and Bajjika	English (for Western comparison)
Basic word order	Subject–Object–Verb (SOV)	Subject–Verb–Object (SVO)
Adpositions	Postpositions, following the noun	Prepositions, preceding the noun
Honorificity	Mandatory grammatical agreement in pronoun and verb forms	Predominantly lexical politeness strategies
Word-order flexibility	Highly flexible according to context	Comparatively stable and rigid

Videha Parallel Criticism and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

The intellectual movement represented by the book stands upon the Videha Parallel History Framework established by Gajendra Thakur. That framework deconstructs the traditional elite literary history supported by the Sahitya Akademi—a history described here as predominantly centred upon Maithil Brahmins—and advocates a democratic, polyphonic, feminist, Dalit and regional history that includes the Terai of Nepal.

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Application of Navya-Nyāya

Parallel criticism derives its epistemology from the Navya-Nyāya initiated by the great fourteenth-century Maithil philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. The rigorous and subtle treatment of pramāṇa (means of knowledge), anumāna (inference) and vyāpti (invariable concomitance) in Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi forms the basis on which Videha criticism assesses literary claims.

Videha's proposed 'vyāpti' is that wherever there is genuine literary vitality, the presence of neglected, folk, Dalit and women's voices is essential: 'Wherever there is genuine Maithili literary vitality, there is inclusivity of subaltern, non-Brahmin, and marginalised voices.' On the foundation of this rigorous Navya-Nyāya idea of evidence, the Dalit autobiography of Sandeep Kumar Safi, the children's literature of Preeti Thakur, the parallel theatre of Bechan Thakur, and the Anchinhar Akhar ghazal movement—in which Siyarām Jha 'Saras' and Ashish Anchinhar have made significant contributions—have been established within the mainstream. Gajendra Thakur's 'parallel' discourse is, in fact, not a marginal discourse but a history that was long delayed and is nevertheless truthful: 'The Parallel is not the marginal, but the truthful, in long delay.'

Comparative Examination through Universal Literary Theory

This book on grammar and composition is evaluated not only in the light of Indian theories—rasa, dhvani and vakrokti—or Western theories such as structuralism and New Criticism, but also through literary and linguistic theories from across East and West-Central Asia.

Chinese Theory: Liu Xie's Wenxin Diaolong

In his monumental fifty-chapter work Wenxin Diaolong (The Literary Mind and the Carving of Dragons), the fifth-century Chinese critic Liu Xie developed the cosmic conception of wen, meaning pattern or literature. According to Liu Xie, literature, or wen, is neither external ornament nor artificial construction. It is the natural expression of cosmic order—the patterns of the universe—and of the inner character of the human mind, an externalisation of the inner mind.

In the grammar of Maithili, Thethi-Angika and Bajjika, this wen, or pattern, is clearly discernible in honorific pronouns and verbal agreement. Just as the hierarchical pronouns described here as 'zhen' (for the emperor) and 'zaisha' (for a servant) in Chinese literature are said to represent a hierarchy of nature, so the multidimensional hierarchy of the Maithili–Bajjika family—'हम-तौंह-अहाँ-अपने' (first person and successive levels of second-person honorification: 1st, 2NH, 2MH, 2H, 2HH), and the third-person forms 'ऊ-ओ-ई-ए'—is the linguistic wen, or pattern, of society's cosmic and social order. Further, just as the omission of pronouns in Chinese poetry brings the human being into union with nature, verbal agreement suffixes are so richly developed in Maithili that a complete meaning can be conveyed without an explicit subject pronoun. This represents, in the author's account, a highest expression of wen.

Japanese Theory: Mono no Aware and Kotodama

In Japanese literary thought, mono no aware signifies the pathos or poignant beauty of things; kotodama signifies the spiritual or emotional power of words.

The digital documentation of Mithila's folk songs, songs dedicated to the goddess Gosāuni, ritual performances and songs associated with life-cycle rites in the Videha Parallel Audio-Video Archive is, in the author's interpretation, clearly grounded in the principle of kotodama. The emotional and persuasive force of a folk song cannot be conveyed by written text alone. The beauty of sound and the profound pathos of popular experience embodied in Bajjika and Thethi-Angika folk arts and songs offer apt examples of mono no aware. Through its references to audio-visual materials, the book presents language not merely as a thing printed on paper but as a power of sound—kotodama.

Tibetan Theory: Thonmi Sambhoṭa's Sumcupa and the Kāvyādarśa

The Sumcupa, attributed to Thonmi Sambhoṭa, regarded as the founder of Tibetan linguistics, and the Tibetan translation of the great Sanskrit scholar Daṇḍin's Kāvyādarśa illuminate both linguistic structure and its poetic possibilities. Tibetan theory relates grammar to philosophy and the

local phonetic system. The comparative synthesis in Chapter 741 of the book, on phonetics, brings together the Sanskrit Śikṣā tradition—guttural, palatal, retroflex, dental and labial places of articulation—and Western phonetics—velar, palatal, retroflex, dental and bilabial. It recalls the translation tradition associated with the Tibetan Sumcupa, in which Indian linguistic structures were adapted to the sounds of Tibetan. The book makes clear that these articulatory categories belong to the Indo-Aryan inheritance as a whole, while their functional distribution varies regionally.

Israeli Theory: Ghil'ad Zuckermann's Revivalistics

The Israeli linguist Ghil'ad Zuckermann is internationally known for the development of 'revivalistics', the study of language revival. His theory of phono-semantic matching (PSM) describes a striking process of word formation under language contact, in which a foreign or borrowed word is adapted to the sound and meaning of a local language to create a new form —a 'camouflaged borrowing'. Zuckermann has explained the hybridity produced by Yiddish and other languages in the development of Israeli Hebrew.

Zuckermann refers to dead or neglected languages as 'sleeping beauties' and emphasises their revival as a means of preventing cultural dependence and the loss of a community's soul. Thethi-Angika and Bajjika have long been neglected by the mainstream, which dismisses them as mere 'dialects'. The book seeks to standardise their grammar and develop their vocabulary on the lines of Zuckermann's revivalistics. Its discussion of vitality and intergenerational transmission in Chapter 893, 'Language Ecology', is directly inspired, in this account, by Israeli theories of revival. Its 'Exercise L', placed before the creation of new words, is a practical application of Israeli-style lexical engineering to neologisation.

Other Applications of Indian and Western Critical Theory

The Videha method of criticism uses the Indian tradition—Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, rasa, dhvani, aucitya and vakrokti—together with postcolonial and subaltern perspectives. Bhartṛhari's theory of sphoṭa in the Vākyapadīya holds that meaning arises not from any single sound or letter but from an indivisible apprehension of the entire sentence, a 'meaning of meaning'. The progression described in Chapter 899, 'Grammaticalisation', from lexical meaning towards grammatical function is presented as a modern form of the sphoṭa theory. Where Western theory discusses Jürgen Habermas's 'public sphere', this book and the Videha archive represent a successful attempt to create a new linguistic public sphere and a digital renaissance for Maithili, Bajjika and Angika.

Part Two — Volume One: Thethi-Angika Grammar and Composition

2.1 The Foundational Grammar of Chapters 1–20

The opening sequence of Volume One arranges the subjects of Thethi-Angika from Chapters 1 to 20: introduction, phonetics, the study of words, nouns, pronouns, adjectives, verbs, indeclinables, compounds, word formation, syntax, prose, poetry, idioms and proverbs, word meaning, paragraphs and essays, letters, dialogue, metres and figures of speech. Pedagogically, this is a natural progression: sounds → words → forms → sentences → composition → poetry.

The attempt to explain local forms through the local language itself is particularly important in the opening chapters. Definitions of grammar, language families, speech areas, dialect differences, script, parts of speech, inflected and uninflected words, vowels and consonants, places of articulation, the origins of words, short, long and other forms, gender, number and case, pronouns, adjectives and verbal forms supply a firm foundation for beginning readers.

Nevertheless, the relation between these chapters and the later linguistics section would be clearer if traditional phonetic classification were accompanied from the outset by the IPA, acoustic measurement and variation in regional pronunciation. Sanskrit-based classes of 'places of articulation' are useful, but actual recordings of speech, minimal contrasts and differences among speakers would provide scientific confirmation.

2.2 Verbs, the Relation to the Hearer, and Semantic Subtlety

Original Thethi-Angika examples: 'ऊ खैलखौं? · ऊ खाय छौ ।' as against 'ऊ खैलकै? · ऊ खाय छै ।'

The discussion of the relationship to the hearer in Thethi-Angika verbs is among the most interesting elements of this volume. It presents not simply the traditional table of grammatical 'persons', but the sociogrammatical influence of participants in an utterance. Western pragmatics, the Japanese process perspective and Videha's parallel method would all accord this feature high priority. If a future edition added the full paradigm of addressee-related forms, their interactions with person, respect, tense and aspect, their regional distribution and examples from spontaneous dialogue, the topic could become a research study in its own right.

Original Thethi-Angika examples: 'गिलास में पानी छै ।' and 'ई पानी छेकै ।'

The proposed distinction between 'छै' and 'छेकै' in expressions of existence and identification is also semantically important. Such contrasts should be tested not merely by assigning meanings to isolated sentences, but through negation, questions, emphasis, tense, context and regional usage. If speakers do not all maintain the same distinction, it would be more scientific to describe it as a 'tendency' or a 'regional distribution' than as a 'general rule'.

2.3 The Art of Composition: Chapters 12–20

The sequence devoted to prose genres, verse, idioms and proverbs, word meanings, paragraphs and essays, letters, dialogue, metres and figures of speech resists the narrow view that Thethi-Angika is only a language of everyday conversation. Once a language is used for stories, essays, dialogue, poetry and critical writing, its standardisation becomes not merely a question of spelling but one of its capacity across genres.

From the Indian perspectives of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti, the chapter on verse need not stop at lists of metres and figures of speech: it could also consider the reader's experience, implied meaning and contextual appropriateness. From the Chinese perspective of compositional arrangement, the prose chapter could expand exercises on beginning, middle and end, coherence between paragraphs, imagery, rhythm and style.

2.4 Extended Practical Reorganisation after Chapter 20

After the first twenty chapters, the book reorganises Thethi-Angika into five parts as a 'practical reference book': language, sounds and writing; word forms; syntax; the art of composition; and exercises and supporting materials. It adds discussions of standard and regional forms, spelling, verbs, tense, aspect and mood, agreement, comparisons with English, editing, answer keys, a style sheet and a list of sources.

For teaching purposes this second presentation extends the earlier chapter sequence, but the repetition can confuse readers at the level of the book's overall structure. A future edition could designate the first twenty chapters as a 'concise course' and the following five parts as an 'expanded reference edition', with cross-references. Repetition would then become a deliberate arrangement of levels instead of a structural defect.

2.5 Assessment of Volume One

The fundamental achievement of the Thethi-Angika volume is to accord this language variety its own grammatical dignity. Its strongest areas are verb systems, addressee relations, local word formation, postpositions and particles, regional forms and practical composition. The principal areas

needing improvement are phonetic evidence, the social basis of standardisation, metadata for regional forms, source tagging for initial rules, and an editorial map of the repeated material.

Supplementary Descriptive Evaluation of the Thethi-Angika Volume

Volume One — Thethi-Angika: Grammar and Composition

The first volume places Thethi-Angika within the sequence Indo-European → Indo-Iranian → Indo-Aryan → Eastern Indo-Aryan (the Magadhan group) → the Bihari subgroup, and briefly traces its history from Grierson's (1903) 'Chhika-Chhiki' identification to its present official-language status in Jharkhand. Its most commendable feature is that it explains Angika grammar not from outside the language, but in Angika prose itself: 'व्याकरण भाषा-प्रयोग के संविधान छेकै' ('Grammar is the constitution of language use'), and 'ठेठी-अंगिका में "है" के मतलब लेली छिकै/छेकै/छै क्रिया के व्यवहार होय छै' ('In Thethi-Angika the verbs छिकै/छेकै/छै are used to convey the sense of "is"'). This style of self-description establishes linguistic autonomy in the very form of its exposition.

Examples of Angika honorific forms (from the book): 'हम्में अपने पढ़ै छी।' · 'अपनें बोलियै नी।' Respectful reference: इनी/हिनी (near), हुनी/हुन्ही (far). Subject forms: हम, हमें, हम्में, हमरा.

Part One of this volume (grammar, Chapters 1–17) covers inflected and uninflected words; vowels, vowel length and nasalisation; consonant articulation; nouns, gender and number; case and postpositions; pronouns and honorification; tense, aspect and mood of verbs; and word formation. Part Two (composition, from Chapter 18 onwards) deals with syntax, paragraphs, letters, essays, dialogue, news, précis-writing, translation and editing. Chapter 41, containing a 'style sheet for writing', and Chapter 42, on 'sources and editorial limitations', both attest to the author's concern with authenticity: he explicitly acknowledges both his source texts and their limitations.

Preliminary evaluation: Volume One is pedagogically well organised, authentic in its self-presentation and faithful to its source texts. Its limitation is that it relies mainly on a single foundation text (Amarendra–Purve). Consequently, disputes or omissions in that source will be reflected here. The author himself acknowledges this, stating that 'independent verification of academic claims is necessary'. Such candour deserves praise.

Part Three — Volume Two: Bajjika Grammar and Composition

3.1 The Structure of Fourteen Parts and Three Appendices

In its initial presentation, the Bajjika volume comprises fourteen parts: introduction; phonology; nouns; pronouns; adjectives; counting and numerals; verbs; adverbs; postpositions and particles; conjunctions; interjections; sentence construction; word formation; and composition. These are followed by three appendices: a dictionary of idioms and proverbs, a Bajjika–Hindi dictionary, and a workbook. The arrangement combines traditional grammar with vocabulary and practical exercises.

The composition section is especially important to the standardisation of Bajjika, since a standard that is not supported by an expanding written tradition will remain confined to a rulebook. Letters, essays, conversations, news reports, summaries and translations constitute actual domains in which the written language is used.

3.2 Standard Forms versus Regional Variants

Examples of regional and alternative forms presented in the original book: “हए/हइ/छै; सभ/सब; रउआ/रउरा; हमर/हमार”.

Variation of this kind is both a strength of the Bajjika volume and its most difficult editorial question. Western sociolinguistics would regard the distribution of variants not as “errors” but as sociogeographical data. An Israeli approach to standard-setting would insist that the choice of a written standard is bound up with community acceptance, publication, education and prestige. The Videha parallel method would require the source, locality, speaker and context to be recorded for each form.

On this basis, the book's policy of selecting a principal written form is practical; nevertheless, the methodology associated with the word “standard” must be explicit. Does the choice rest on mutual intelligibility, geographical extent, literary usage, ease of teaching, historical tradition, institutional acceptance—or some combination of these? Answering this question would give the written introduction a scientific foundation.

3.3 Pronouns, Honorification, Verbs and Dialogue

Bajjika example: “रउआ कहाँ जा रहल हई?” [Where are you going?—using a respectful form of address.]

Honorific pronouns such as रउआ/रउरा, possessive forms such as हमर/हमार, regional forms of auxiliary verbs, and differences in negation constitute significant areas of social grammar in Bajjika. The Japanese study of particles and interpersonal relations, together with Tokieda's

process-oriented perspective, takes this discussion beyond a mere table of forms. Which form does a particular speaker select when addressing a particular listener? If the dialogue chapter supplied minimal pairs of such social situations, both teaching and research would benefit.

3.4 The Expanded Five-Part Practical Version

Later in the volume, Bajjika is arranged again in an expanded five-part structure: language, sounds and writing; words and forms; sentence structure; composition; and exercises, answers and tables. This reorganisation places the contents of the original fourteen parts in a modern, practical sequence. Spelling, morphology, sentences, questions, relationships, composition and supporting tables receive more systematic treatment.

From an editorial standpoint, the relationship between these two versions should be made clear. One possibility is to describe the fourteen-part concise grammar as the “foundation text” and the five-part version as “expanded reference and practice”. Repeated rules could then carry cross-references such as “See: Foundation Text, Part …”.

3.5 Assessment of Volume Two

The principal achievement of the Bajjika volume is its systematisation of linguistic forms and its integration of honorific pronouns, verbs, postpositions, sentence structures and composition within a single course. The principal areas requiring improvement are an evidential map of regional variation, a clear policy for selecting standard forms, sound recordings, natural dialogue, source information for dictionary entries, and structural integration of the second practical version.

Supplementary Review of the Bajjika Volume: Grammar, Lexicography, Proverbs and Sociolinguistic Context

Volume Two — Bajjika: Grammar, Lexicon and Proverbs

The Bajjika volume is divided into twelve parts—introduction, phonology, nouns, pronouns, adjectives, counting, verbs, adverbs, postpositions and particles, conjunctions, interjections, and sentence construction—and three substantial appendices: a dictionary of idioms and proverbs, a Bajjika–Hindi dictionary, and a workbook. Two elements are particularly valuable: its account of the pragmatically grounded honorific system and its extensive lexicographical appendix.

Bajjika levels of address (from the book): 'तूँ' (ordinary) as against 'रउआ/अहाँ' (respectful). Verb forms (the root 'खा-', 'to eat', simple present):

हम — खाइले · तूँ — खालऽ · अपने — खाइले · ऊ (singular) — खाले · ऊ (plural) — खालन.

This verbal paradigm brings to light a subtle linguistic fact: person and honorification are encoded in Bajjika verbs not only grammatically but pragmatically, a point supported, according to the book's bibliography, by the research of Kashyap (2012, Journal of Pragmatics) and Kashyap–Yap (2017, Linguistics). The author's "zero-invention policy" is clearly visible here. He repeatedly writes, "ए निष्कर्ष के अउर वक्ता/कॉर्पस से जाँच बाकी हए"—that is, "This conclusion still needs to be checked against further speakers or a corpus." Where the evidence is limited, the claim is correspondingly limited.

The sizeable Bajjika–Hindi dictionary in Appendix Two and the collection of proverbs in Appendix One—classified under such topics as women, wealth and pride, and practical conduct—are records of popular wisdom. A critical caution is necessary here: proverbs concerning women often embody patriarchal values. Recording them is linguistically justified, for they are facts of vernacular usage, but a future edition ought to accompany such material with critical commentary, particularly in view of the Videha movement's declared support for women's voices.

Preliminary assessment: the Bajjika volume is grounded in data and rich in lexicographical material. Its methodological modesty—the explicit acknowledgment of insufficient data where necessary—is exemplary.

The Sociolinguistics and Grammar of Thethi-Angika and Bajjika

In the history of linguistics, Sir George Abraham Grierson, in his Linguistic Survey of India (LSI, 1903), treated Angika—which he called "Chhika-Chhiki"—and Bajjika, or Western Maithili, as dialects of Maithili. Over time, however, questions of language, caste and identity arose, and these marginalised groups began struggling for independent linguistic recognition. The book makes clear, from Chapter 694 onward, that the distinction between a language and a dialect is entirely social.

Grammatical and Phonological Examples from Bajjika and Thethi-Angika (in Standard Devanagari)

The book presents morphological examples from Bajjika and Thethi-Angika in a fully standardised and correctly rendered Devanagari script, without font-rendering defects.

Distinctive Features and Examples of Bajjika: Bajjika is spoken in Vaishali, Muzaffarpur, Sitamarhi, Sheohar and Samastipur, as well as in Nepal's Rautahat and Sarlahi districts. It has eight vowels and thirty consonants. Consonant gemination is common, as in 'मज्जिल' (funeral journey),

'हम्मर' (my/mine), and 'निम्मन' (good). Sentence example: "राम घर जा रहल छै।" [Ram is going home.] Pronouns and honorification include "हमनी" [we] and the respectful "रउआ" [you].

Distinctive Features and Examples of Thethi-Angika: Angika, spoken in the Bhagalpur, Munger, Banka and Dumka regions, uses distinctive pronouns and suffixes. Examples: "हम जायछी।" [I am going.] "हम गेलीये।" [I went.] "ई की छिकै।" [What is this?]

Language Contact and Structural Change

Viewed from the perspective of the sociolinguistic analyses, particularly Chapters 892 and 888, a striking fact emerges. Although Bajjika originated as part of Maithili (Western Maithili), it is now undergoing structural change for sociopolitical reasons.

The study states that Bajjika speakers, especially the younger generation, are adopting grammatical elements from Bhojpuri, a language to the west, as a strategy of distancing their speech from what they perceive as the cultural and linguistic dominance of Maithil Brahmins. Earlier Bajjika auxiliaries resembled Maithili 'छ' (chh), while past-tense marking was zero or otherwise distinct; younger speakers are now using Bhojpuri 'हवे' (hawe) as an auxiliary and the present/past suffix '-ल' (-la). According to the source, these new forms appear in approximately 20–22 per cent of usage. This is a vivid instance of language contact, diffusion and structural convergence. It is not merely a linguistic change but a serious social contest over identity and language attitudes, which the book records impartially.

Part Four — Volume Three: Maithili Grammar and Composition, Chapters 21–693

4.1 Chapters 21–43: Traditional Foundations

Chapters 21–43 lay the foundations in language introduction, the alphabet, pronunciation, sandhi, words, nouns, gender, number, case, pronouns, adjectives, verbs, adverbs, indeclinables, sentence structure, voice, sentence types, letters, essays, dialogue, translation and précis writing, punctuation, metres and figures of speech. This traditional teaching sequence supplies students with familiar grammatical terminology.

From the standpoint of the Indian tradition, this is pedagogically useful; modern linguistics, however, calls for certain traditional categories to be redefined. For example, the semantic role denoted by 'kāraka' must be distinguished from the actual postpositional marker; grammatical from

social meanings of gender; morphological from discourse functions of voice; and classical rules of sandhi from contemporary pronunciation. These distinctions should remain explicit.

4.2 Chapters 44–61: Language, Sentences and Social Relations

This group develops the foundations of language, grammar, sentences, words, phrases, clauses, meaning, composition and social relations. Its particular importance lies in relating grammar to social relationships. It can serve as a bridge between Indian theories of sentence meaning, Hallidayan functionalism and Tokieda's interpersonal conception of language. The criterion for a "correct sentence" should include not only rules but also context, purpose and appropriateness to the listener.

Boundary verification: this group of the review extends from Chapter 44, "Language, Grammar and Composition", to Chapter 61, "Five Foundations for Constructing a Correct Sentence".

4.3 Chapters 62–89: Nouns, Number, Case, Pronouns and Honorification

From nominal construction to comparison with English pronouns, this group expands the analysis of noun phrases. The treatment of plural marking, classifiers, postpositions, person, honorification, demonstratives, reflexive and relative forms in Maithili yields important language-specific data. From the Videha parallel perspective, it would be particularly productive to compare these forms with Thethi-Angika and Bajjika while eliciting the same meanings.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 62, "The Expanded Structure of Nouns", to Chapter 89, "Common Errors in Pronouns and Their Correction".

4.4 Chapters 90–124: Verbs, Tense–Aspect–Mood, Auxiliaries and Comparison

Verb roots, transitivity, tense–aspect–mood, auxiliaries, agreement, negation, modality, compound verbs, infinitive-like forms and comparison with English constitute the backbone of modern grammar in this group. It can be read in the light of both Pāṇinian morphological precision and Western analysis of TAM. What is most needed is a naturally occurring example for each form, tests involving negation and questions, the level of honorification, and evidence of regional distribution.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 90, "What Is a Verb?", to Chapter 124, "A Practical Comparison with the English Adjective/Determiner System".

4.5 Chapters 125–160: Adverbs, Particles, Postpositions, Conjunctions and Emphasis

Here the smaller words—adverbs, particles, postpositions, connectors and emphatic forms—become central to meaning and syntactic relationships. The Japanese tenioha tradition and Tibetan relational grammar enhance the critical value of this section. Further minimal pairs should demonstrate whether changing the position of a particle alters focus, meaning or politeness.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 125, "What Is an Adverb?", to Chapter 160, "Common Errors and Corrections".

4.6 Chapters 161–203: Sentence Types, Questions, Information Structure, Voice and Reported Speech

Assertions, questions, commands, negation, information structure, transformation, voice, direct and indirect speech, and quotation carry grammar towards discourse. In the perspectives of Austin and Grice, the actual speech act performed by a sentence—an order, request, suggestion or sarcastic remark—may differ from its formal sentence type. Cross-references to the dialogue material in the composition section would therefore be useful.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 161, "A Modern Perspective on Sentence Types", to Chapter 203, "Mixed Reported Speech and Quotation".

4.7 Chapters 204–260: Clauses and Word Formation

From main and subordinate, complement, relative, adverbial and conditional clauses to prefixes, suffixes, compounds, reduplication, borrowed words and technical coinages, this group illustrates productivity at both sentence and word levels. Comparisons with external categories are useful, but Maithili's own patterns of formation should be described first. Four criteria should guide the creation of technical terms: established usage, transparency, brevity and community acceptance.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 204, "Main and Subordinate Clauses", to Chapter 260, "A Practical Comparison with English Word Formation".

4.8 Chapters 261–323: Orthography, Devanagari, Editing and Paragraphs

This extensive group—correct writing, Devanagari, punctuation, editing, digital writing, style sheets, sentence correction, paragraph development and coherence—connects grammar with actual publishing skills. This

practical orientation distinguishes the book. A future edition could add guidance on cross-script use of Tirhuta, Devanagari and digital Unicode forms, together with checks for searchability, copying and pasting, and accessibility.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 261, "Fundamental Principles of Correct Writing", to Chapter 323, "Comprehensive Revision of a Weak Paragraph".

4.9 Chapters 324–397: Genres of Composition, Argument, Criticism and Academic Writing

Narration and description, letters, email, notices, news, summaries, essays, argumentative writing, claims and evidence, fallacies, reviews, speeches, editorials, proposals, minutes of meetings, biography and academic writing form the literary and practical heart of the book. Indian aucitya, dhvani and vakrokti, Chinese principles of compositional arrangement, and Western rhetoric and discourse theory are all applicable here. A formula emerging from the group is: "Writing = subject + reader + purpose + style + evidence + revision."

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 324, "The Purpose, Reader and Voice of a Composition", to Chapter 397, "Editorial Review of Advanced Composition".

4.10 Chapters 398–477: Style, Register, Meaning, Lexical Relationships and Context

Style, register, social distance, precision, ambiguity, rhythm, idioms, proverbs, figures of speech, genre, stylistic variation, polysemy, synonyms, antonyms, lexical fields, collocation, metaphor, context and semantic verification connect literary criticism with semantics in this group. The perspectives of dhvani, vakrokti and pragmatics are especially apt. Corroborating dictionary meanings through corpus collocations will be an important future direction.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 398, "What Is Style?", to Chapter 477, "Practical Checklist for Testing Meaning".

4.11 Chapters 478–574: Phonetics, Pronunciation, Reading, Editing and Publishing Checks

From sounds, speech organs, phonemes, syllables, rhythm, intonation, reading and editing recordings to proofreading, page design, tables, citations, references, fonts, visual inspection of PDFs and images, version control and editorial ethics, this group presents the "life cycle" of linguistic material. Principles such as "Do not change facts; do not distort

the author's intention; do not remove necessary material; do not add new claims" provide a firm basis for editorial ethics.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 478, "Sound, Syllable and Phoneme", to Chapter 574, "Final Editorial Checklist".

4.12 Chapters 575–620: Integrated Diagnosis, Revision, Exercises and Assessment

This group covers the diagnosis of errors at different levels of language, revision of nouns, pronouns, verbs and sentences, exercises, question papers, outlines of answers and self-assessment. Pedagogically, it works as mastery learning. In an improved edition, every exercise could be tagged with a learning objective, difficulty level, rationale for the model answer and diagnosis of common mistakes.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 575, "Integrated Diagnosis: At What Level Is the Language Error?", to Chapter 620, "Self-Assessment Checklist".

4.13 Chapters 621–676: Quick Reference, Templates, Error Lists, Glossary and Self-Testing

This section enables readers to navigate the enormous book efficiently. Quick-reference tables, templates for composition, common errors, a glossary and self-tests are necessary features of a practical reference work. A digital edition could link this section to hyperlinks, search terms, downloadable forms and a machine-readable glossary.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 621, "How to Use This Reference Section", to Chapter 676, "Answers to the Quick Self-Test".

4.14 Chapters 677–693: Structural Mapping, Indexing, Final Review and Completion

The concluding group provides a structural map of the entire work, checks repetition and terminological consistency, and supplies indexes, final editorial inspection and closure. Self-auditing is necessary for a work of this scale, but the audit could be made more rigorous with explicit tables such as a chapter–source matrix, a terminology register and a map of duplication.

Boundary verification: this group extends from Chapter 677, "Structural Map of the Complete Work", to Chapter 693, "Completion of the Book".

4.15 Integrated Assessment of Volume Three

The extraordinary strength of the Maithili volume lies in its breadth and staged practicality. Beginning with traditional grammar and proceeding through modern syntax, semantics, pragmatics, style, composition, editing, phonetics, pre-publication inspection and self-assessment, it points towards a "complete language-skills system" for Maithili.

Its principal risk is its sheer size. With 693 chapters, readers need clear pathways for beginners, intermediate students, advanced learners and researchers. If repetition is intentional and designed for spiral learning, it should be identified as such; unnecessary duplication should be consolidated. Attaching source tags and corpus or fieldwork evidence to each advanced claim would allow Volume Three to develop from a teaching manual into a research reference work.

Supplementary Descriptive Evaluation of the Maithili Volume

Volume Three — Maithili: Grammar and Composition (Chapters 21–693)

This is the largest and most central volume of the work. Its first unit (Chapters 21–43) follows the sequence of traditional grammar teaching: an introduction to language and grammar, the alphabet, rules of pronunciation and sound, sandhi, the study of words, nouns, gender, number, case, pronouns, adjectives, verbs, adverbs, indeclinables, sentence structure and word order, voice, sentence types and clauses, letters, essays, dialogue, translation and précis writing, punctuation, metres and figures of speech. The appendices supply a glossary of technical terms, an answer key, complete verb paradigms and the Tirhuta script.

The work provides an exceptionally precise account of a feature for which Maithili is well known in international linguistics: multidimensional verbal agreement. A Maithili verb changes not only according to the subject but also in relation to the honorific status of another person present in the sentence, whether the object or a related individual.

Examples of multidimensional agreement (from the book): with the same subject, 'हम' (I), compare "ओकरा हम देखलिऐ" [I saw him/her; non-honorific object] and "हुनका हम देखलियनि" [I saw him/her; honorific object]. Changing only the honorific status of the object changes the verb form from 'देखलिऐ' to 'देखलियनि'.

Further on, Volume Three includes two additional, extensive methodological units. One is a detailed, unit-based grammar of Maithili informed by modern linguistics (from Chapter 44 onwards), treating nouns, pronouns, verbs, adjectives, adverbs and syntax in depth, unit by

unit, with extensive exercises, answers and principles of composition accompanying each unit. The other is a section on "parallel composition and editing" (from Chapter 280 onwards), discussing parallelism, consistency of tense and honorification, terminological consistency, the three stages of editing, visual inspection of digital publications and the style sheet. At this point the work moves beyond pedagogical grammar into editorial science, a natural response to the practical requirements of a digital publishing institution such as Videha.

Preliminary assessment: in terms of subject matter, Volume Three is perhaps the most extensive modern instructional compilation of Maithili grammar. Its limitation is structural: successive compilations organised according to different methods have been brought together, so some topics—such as introductions to nouns, pronouns and verbs—recur at different levels of depth. This need not be a defect, but clearer organisation in final editing, for instance with explicit "introductory" and "advanced" labels, would improve readability.

Part Five — Volume Four: Linguistics, Chapters 694–926

5.1 Chapters 694–708: Foundations of Thethi-Angika Linguistics

The nature of linguistics, phonetics, phonology, writing systems and the IPA, morphology, word classes, syntax, negation, interrogation and information structure, semantics, pragmatics and discourse, sociolinguistics, history, typology, psycholinguistics, and fieldwork, corpora and computational methods: this fifteen-chapter framework provides an almost complete introduction to the discipline. It is significant that modern subfields are presented through examples drawn from Thethi-Angika.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 694, "The Nature of Linguistics and Scientific Methods", to Chapter 708, "Fieldwork, Corpora, Documentation and Computational Linguistics".

5.2 Chapters 709–723: Corresponding Foundations of Bajjika Linguistics

The same subjects are applied to Bajjika as to Thethi-Angika. An equivalent arrangement of chapters benefits comparative study, since researchers can examine a single feature—such as phonemes, word order or sociolinguistic variation—across all three languages. Identical headings, however, must not imply identical conclusions: data particular to each language should remain independent.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 709, "The Nature of Linguistics and Scientific Methods", to Chapter 723, "Fieldwork, Corpora, Documentation and Computational Linguistics".

5.3 Chapters 724–738: Corresponding Foundations of Maithili Linguistics

The Maithili sequence adds supporting materials such as scientific methods, the IPA, fieldwork forms, a small corpus of one hundred sentences and the stages of research. This provides a direct bridge between teaching and research. A corpus can be small at the outset, but its metadata, genre balance and diversity of speakers ought to be clearly documented.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 724, "The Nature of Linguistics and Scientific Method", to Chapter 738, "Fieldwork, Corpora, Documentation and Computational Linguistics".

5.4 Chapters 739–768: Genealogy, Sounds, Forms, Sentences, Meaning, Society, History and Script Technology

After establishing the foundations for all three languages, this group undertakes a more integrated analysis. Genealogical classification, vowels and consonants, syllables and stress, morphophonology, nouns, pronouns and verbs, word order, alignment, clauses, question–negation–focus relations, semantics and pragmatics, dialect geography, language contact, historical change, graphology, Tirhuta, Kaithi and Devanagari, and transliteration and language technology extend the study of linguistics well beyond the customary limits of a textbook.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 739, "What Is Linguistics?", to Chapter 768, "Transliteration and Language Technology".

5.5 Chapters 769–783: Advanced Research Methods in Thethi-Angika

This group develops advanced approaches to primary linguistic data, fieldwork ethics, acoustic analysis, phonology, transliteration, morphology, syntax, semantics, social factors, history, typology, psycholinguistics, corpora and lexicography. The scientific spirit of the injunction "Formulate a rule, then search for an example that would disprove it" is especially valuable.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 769, "The Nature, Branches and Scientific Method of Linguistics", to Chapter 783, "Corpora, Dictionaries, Documentation and Computational Linguistics".

5.6 Chapters 784–798: Advanced Research Methods in Bajjika

The same research design is repeated for Bajjika. This repetition facilitates comparisons between subjects but increases the length of the book. A digital edition could achieve a more economical structure by placing

common methodological material in one location and language-specific data in separate modules.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 784, “The Nature, Branches and Scientific Methods of Linguistics”, to Chapter 798, “Corpora, Dictionaries, Documentation and Computational Linguistics”.

5.7 Chapters 799–813: Advanced Research Methods in Maithili

The Maithili series expands the treatment of evidence, reproducibility, phonetics, morphology, syntax, semantics, society, history, typology, psycholinguistics, documentation and computational linguistics. This section is especially useful for higher education and research training.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 799, “Linguistics: Subject, Branches, Evidence and Reproducibility”, to Chapter 813, “Corpora, Lexicography, Documentation and Computational Linguistics”.

5.8 Chapters 814–826: The Core of the Parallel Method

Comparability, controls, source support, minimum sample sizes, research ethics, sounds, noun phrases, pronouns and honorification, verbal TAM, syntax, semantics and pragmatics, sociolinguistics, history, typology, corpora, fieldwork and technical terminology: these thirteen chapters can be regarded as the intellectual centre of the whole work. The principle “One question, all three languages” gives this book a distinctive identity beyond that of an ordinary comparative grammar.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 814, “Method of Parallel Study: Comparable Data, Controls and Evidence”, to Chapter 826, “Bilingual Technical Terminology: English Term + Mandatory Indian/Maithili Equivalent”.

5.9 Chapters 827–850: Research Design, Experiments, Data and Comparative Claims

Variables, samples, controls, measurement, experimental phonetics, sociophonetics, experimental grammar, psycholinguistics, language acquisition, multilingualism, contact, applied linguistics, translation, dictionaries, digital tools, archives and evidence for comparative claims make this group particularly rich in methodology. Introducing randomisation, counterbalancing, reproducibility and preregistration into the study of local languages represents a significant scientific advance.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 827, “Research Design, Variables, Sampling, Controls and Reproducibility”, to Chapter 850, “Similarity, Difference and Evidence: How to Write a Comparative Claim”.

5.10 Chapters 851–858: Corpus Projects and Quality Assurance

File structures, speaker metadata, recordings, transcriptions, normalised texts, interlinear analysis, lexicons and structures resembling Universal Dependencies, and corpus quality assurance make this section highly useful for constructing digital language resources. A future edition could also include a model licence, consent form, versioning conventions, persistent identifiers and a checksum policy.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 851, “Corpus Project Units and File Structures”, to Chapter 858, “Corpus Quality Assurance and Reproduction”.

5.11 Chapters 859–877: Diagnostic Work from Phonology to Sentence Structure

Phonemes and allophones, minimal contrasts, phonological processes, morphemes, allomorphs, inflection and derivation, valency, argument structure, phrases, dependencies, relative and complement clauses, coordination and subordination, and information structure take the form of analytical exercises in this group. A parallel dataset of authentic examples from the three languages could greatly increase these chapters' research value.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 859, “Phoneme and Allophone: Differences in Meaning versus Differences in Pronunciation”, to Chapter 877, “Relative Clauses, Complements, Coordination, Subordination and Information Structure”.

5.12 Chapters 878–883: Semantics, Pragmatics, Discourse and Conversation

Lexical meaning, semantic relations, sentence meaning, deixis, implicature, speech acts, discourse and conversation analysis connect grammar with actual communication. Indian dhvani theory, Gricean implicature, Tokieda's process perspective and Chinese and Japanese studies of particles can enter into dialogue here.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 878, “Lexical Semantics: Lexeme, Sense, Reference”, to Chapter 883, “Conversation Analysis and Practical Annotation Laboratory”.

5.13 Chapters 884–893: Sociolinguistic Variation, Contact, Ecology and Vitality

Sociolinguistic variables, style, identity, regional differences, code-switching, language attitudes, standardisation, contact, ecology, vitality and intergenerational transmission make this group especially important

to the present and future of all three languages. Every decision about standardisation should be re-examined in the light of the evidential approach established here.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 884, “Sociolinguistic Variable and Variant: Variation Is Itself Data”, to Chapter 893, “Language Ecology, Vitality and Intergenerational Transmission”.

5.14 Chapters 894–900: Historical Comparison, Reconstruction and Change

Textual attestation, chronology, the comparative method, sound correspondences, cognates as opposed to loans, reconstruction, analogy, grammaticalisation, inheritance, contact and parallel innovation teach the discipline required for writing historical claims. When citing an older classification such as Grierson's, the distinction between modern data and a community's own sense of identity follows naturally from this method.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 894, “Historical Linguistics: Attestation, Change and Chronology”, to Chapter 900, “How to Distinguish Inheritance, Contact and Parallel Innovation”.

5.15 Chapters 901–908: Typology and Multilingual Processing

Feature–value relations, dominance, word order, alignment, typological comparison, bilingual control, switching costs and multilingual processing place all three languages in the wider perspective of human language. Balanced sampling and control of the influence of English and Hindi are indispensable here.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 901, “Linguistic Typology: Feature, Value and Dominance”, to Chapter 908, “Language Control, Switching Cost, Multilingual Processing and Local Experimental Design”.

5.16 Chapters 909–919: Hierarchies of Evidence, Source Banks and Bases of Analysis

Evidence hierarchies, source citations, the status of examples, banks of examples from all three languages, paradigms, charts, and references for syntax, semantics, pragmatics and discourse are crucial to the reliability of the entire book. Linking each important rule in the earlier Chapters 1–813 back to this hierarchy of evidence would considerably strengthen the book's evidentiary architecture.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 909, “Evidence Hierarchy, Source Citation and Example Status”, to Chapter 919, “Pragmatics and Discourse: From Deixis to Conversation Analysis”.

5.17 Chapters 920–926: Integrated Exercises, Answers, Glossary, Indexes and Completeness Checks

One hundred and twenty integrated tasks, outlines of answers, a bilingual glossary, abbreviations and symbols, a subject index, an index of languages and forms, and a 12/12 completeness check are necessary closing instruments for a work of this scale. They enable readers not merely to read the volume but to put it to use.

Boundary verification: from Chapter 920, "Final Integrated Exercises: 120 Tasks", to Chapter 926, "12/12 Completeness Audit: Final Check of Twelve Principal Objectives".

5.19 Integrated Assessment of Volume Four

Volume Four is the most modern and research-oriented part of the book. Its breadth is exceptional: it gives the branches of linguistics a common arrangement across all three languages and proceeds to integrated comparative methods, experimental research, corpora, digital resources, sociolinguistics, history, typology and hierarchies of evidence.

The next stage for this volume is "verification of examples". Each rule should be accompanied by a stable identifier, source, page or recording, speaker metadata, analyst, level of certainty and licence. Where data is unavailable, an assertion should be marked as a "hypothesis", not an "established fact". This single improvement would make the book more reliable as a research monograph, corpus guide and digital reference grammar alike.

Supplementary Integrated Evaluation of Volume Four

Volume Four — Linguistics: A Parallel Study of the Three Languages (Chapters 694–926)

The fourth volume constitutes the intellectual summit of the work. The perspective changes here, from prescriptive grammar to descriptive linguistics. In the introduction, the author himself announces three foundational principles: first, data before anything else—no invented forms; second, parallel comparison—the three languages examined together; third, Western frameworks and indigenous data. This third principle encapsulates the methodology of the entire work; as we shall see, it is also precisely the point at which dialogue with Indian, Chinese and Japanese traditions becomes possible.

The discussion of method in Volume Four (from Chapter 814 onwards) operates at the level of contemporary comparative linguistics. It places "comparability" at the centre and insists on controlling genre, medium, age, region, honorification, education, script and context. It divides

statements into three categories—"supported by the foundational text", "descriptive tendency" and "hypothesis"—and warns against conflating them. This is precisely the epistemic discipline valued both by Navya-Nyāya's discrimination of evidence and by Western philosophy of science.

Example of parallel testing (from the book): "All three languages use Devanagari, but it is not scientific to assume that an identical letter necessarily represents an identical phoneme. Script, phone and phoneme belong to different levels." Minimum-sample table: sounds—three speakers × twenty target words; pronouns and honorification—ten social situations × three speakers; TAM—ten verb roots × eight semantic contexts.

This volume includes every major modern subfield: phonetics, phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, pragmatics, sociolinguistics, historical and comparative linguistics, linguistic typology, psycholinguistics (bilingual word recognition, language control, switching costs), corpora, lexicography, documentation and computational linguistics (OCR, ASR, TTS and NLP). Its appendices extend to dialect-survey forms, a forty-feature dialectometry matrix, a bank of candidates for historical comparison, typological coding sheets and a bilingual-processing laboratory. The final chapter (926) supplies a "12/12 completeness check", listing the presence of each subfield together with the relevant chapter references.

Preliminary assessment: Volume Four approaches the international standard of a "practical linguistics textbook". It has two limitations. First, some chapters—on "What Is Linguistics?", historical comparison, corpora and computational methods, for example—recur more than once, in different standardisations of the three languages, because of successive compilations. This is evident in the chapter numbering: 694, 709, 724, 739, 769, 784 and 799. Second, some typological claims occasionally go beyond the available corpus evidence. The book itself qualifies such claims as "hypotheses", which is intellectually honest, but the boundary between a claim and a hypothesis can sometimes become blurred for the reader.

24. The Origin and Development of the Tirhuta Script

Editorial

(Instructions for students: It is not necessary to practise every letter in the progression from Brahmi to Tirhuta shown in the appendices. Practising one or two letters will suffice. It is more important to pay attention to Appendix 5. Detailed descriptions of inscriptions and the gradual movement of scripts towards Tirhuta have been provided. In your notes, draw from an inscription only the material relevant to the script you are practising from Appendix 5. Memorising everything is neither possible nor necessary. This essay is eight and a half thousand words long; you may prepare notes of 600–1,000 words according to your needs.)

We must distinguish between pictures drawn on the walls of caves and on rocks beside streams, and pictographic writing. If you love me, you might draw my portrait; if you are hunting, you might draw a picture of the hunt. This would make you someone who draws pictures. Such pictures existed in many places in India as well, but a picture-maker does not immediately become a maker of script. The pictures made by a scribe were intended not for artistic embellishment but to meet a need. Here, for instance, make a circle to signify the sun: there is no need to draw a complete likeness. Then establish a relationship between two such pictures, then between two and three, and so on. Pictographic writing thus takes shape.

In a word-based script there is no economy of effort or of space. The distinction may be understood in this way: Tamil has a syllable-based script, Roman is an alphabetic script, while Tirhuta and Devanagari are alpha-syllabic scripts. That is, a script without conjunct letters is alphabet-based. Thus English, written in Roman characters, has no conjunct letters and employs just twenty-six letters of the alphabet; it is therefore written in an alphabetic script. Tamil is syllable-based and consequently belongs to the syllabic category. Tirhuta and Devanagari contain both elements and are therefore alpha-syllabic. Broadly speaking, these three systems may be compared with varṇika metre (English), mātrika metre (Tamil), and the combination of varṇika and mātrika metres (Tirhuta and Devanagari). There is, however, a complication: counting letters in English will not, by itself, create metrical rhythm, so one must count syllables. Since sound is related to the syllable, a word is divided into syllables. Japanese writing is word-based, so this particular problem does not arise there; the term used for a unit of sound can be translated approximately as a syllable, and it is on that basis that the seventeen sound-units of a haiku are counted.

In Tirhuta, Devanagari and Brahmi, what is spoken is written. In the pre-Pāṇinian and Pāṇinian traditions, rules of sandhi were devised on the basis

of sound. The analysis of a karmadhāraya compound is based on its component words: Mahādeva is 'the great god'. When there are more than two constituent words, it becomes a bahuvrīhi, as in Lambodara: 'he whose belly is large', that is, Gaṇeśa. In English, written in Roman script, sandhi takes place in speech but not in writing, although doubled a, doubled b and the like are certainly used to indicate length, and punctuation also performs this function. There is no triple a there; but we, too, have abandoned the pluta, or protracted vowel, beyond the long vowel. This is also why case suffixes are written attached to words in Maithili. Because Tirhuta and Devanagari possess both elements, metres based on both mātrās and letters can be counted in them. Further information on quantitative and syllabic counting is given from page 18 of Topic 1.

Just as a syllable is related to the word, the pada is related to the compound: sound predominates in the former, and the word or its meaning in the latter. In this way the word-based script was a development of phonetic writing. Historical evidence is available for this, and it is from here that the actual study of scripts becomes possible. Three pictographic traditions have been mentioned: the Tigris–Euphrates riverlands (Sumer, followed by Babylon and Assyria), the Nile valley (Egypt), and Crete (Greece). Among the civilisations that succeeded one another beside the Tigris and Euphrates, cuneiform writing first began in Sumer, around 4000 BCE. The Babylonians learnt the script from Sumer, and the Assyrians learnt it from the Babylonians. It was inscribed, using a pointed stylus and roughly 350 signs, on tablets of kneaded clay before the tablets dried; these were subsequently sun-dried or baked in a kiln. Credit for deciphering it in modern times is given to the Englishman Henry Rawlinson. By its third stage it had become word-based.

In Egypt, hieroglyphic writing—in its hieroglyphic, hieratic and demotic forms—was contemporary with cuneiform. It had twenty-four signs, all consonants. There were no vowels, which caused considerable difficulty and ambiguity; to remedy this, additional special signs and pictures were employed. Writing was done with red ink on sheets of papyrus; the word 'paper' is derived from that papyrus. Both cuneiform and hieroglyphic writing proceeded from right to left. Contemporary Chinese writing, by contrast, proceeded from top to bottom. At first there was one sign for a word, but later a word came to be used for an idea. Chinese writing has no alphabet and contains 40,000 signs. The Elamites initially used their own native linear and picture-rich signs, but later adopted cuneiform, employing 113 signs, more than eighty of which were word-based.

The purely alphabet-based writing that developed in Syria–Cyprus and Palestine, and subsequently the script invented in Minoan civilisation, also bore the influence of word-based writing. Two forms of word-based

writing once existed in China; their use came to an end there, but the practice continues in Japan, as discussed briefly above.

This may also be called an alphabet or a letter-based script. In other scripts, the number of signs had grown so large that it became impossible for a child to learn them all. The reason for the development of this kind of writing was economy of effort. A single script could now be used to write several languages.

The cuneiform of Mesopotamia, beside the Tigris and Euphrates—first in Sumer, then Babylon, and afterwards Assyria—never became an alphabet. Evidence exists of a relationship between this script and the Semitic languages. It could develop from pictorial to ideographic and then to phonetic writing. Even as a phonetic script, however, it could satisfy the requirements of nouns, pronouns, verbs and adverbs only through certain modifications. It then became word-based, and at that point its development ceased.

At a later stage the followers of Zarathustra in Mesopotamia made their script predominantly consonantal; it could be called a semi-alphabet. Its tendency towards artificial construction, however, increased, and linguists have also discerned such a tendency in Brahmi.

Crete likewise moved beyond picture-rich line drawings to create a script with 135 signs, based on ideas as well as sounds. Its writing proceeded both from left to right and from right to left.

A sculpture of the second century found at Nagarjunakonda depicts a scene in the court of King Śuddhodana: three soothsayers are interpreting a dream of Queen Māyā, the mother of the Buddha. Below them sits a scribe recording the interpretation. This is the oldest pictorial evidence yet available of the art of writing in India. There are, of course, older forms of evidence, including Harappan civilisation and Aśoka's inscriptions. Numerous inscriptions have also been found between the periods of Harappan culture and Aśoka, among them the Sohgaura copperplate, the Piprahwa Buddhist mound inscription, the stone inscriptions of Mahasthan and Barli, and the Bhattiprolu inscription.

The first use of writing in India occurred in the Harappan civilisation, although its script has not yet been deciphered. Its inscriptions are short; the longest contains twenty-six signs. Evidence of a signboard at the entrance to the settlement of Dholavira, in Gujarat, has been found: it contains nine signs.

Brahmi is written from left to right, and Kharoshthi from right to left. Both, however, developed on the basis of the Indian alphabetic system. Aśoka's inscriptions occur in both Brahmi and Kharoshthi, the latter at

Mansehra and Shahbazgarhi. The English scholar James Prinsep succeeded in deciphering Brahmi in 1837 CE. Credit for deciphering Kharoshthi is jointly given to Colonel Masson and James Prinsep. Aśoka's name is written in these inscriptions as Piyadassi, and in some as Asoka, the Pali–Prakrit form of Aśoka. Aśoka's inscriptions also refer to scribes.

The Nārada Smṛti calls script the supreme eye and records that Brahmā created it.

The Bṛhaspati Smṛti states that memory begins to fail after six months, and that Brahmā therefore created letters written on leaves.

The script was called Brāhmī; this designation had been accepted by grammarians before Pāṇini. But the form Brāhmī was considered incorrect according to Pāṇinian grammar, and so the name became Brahmi. Pāṇini's Aṣṭādhyāyī and Amarasiṃha's Amarakośa discuss lipi and libi. In the Nirukta, Yāska, a grammarian before Pāṇini, names numerous earlier and contemporary grammarians. The existence of metres based on counting letters, and the presence of grammarians, indirectly suggest the existence of an art of writing. Three thousand years ago, between the Jhelum and Chenab rivers, in Gandhāra—where the Yusufzai Pathans now live—there was the confederated state of Dakṣa. In that region the Kabul River comes from the west to meet the Indus. Pāṇini was born four miles north of that confluence, in a small village belonging to his maternal grandmother; the village was then called Śalātura. The Chinese traveller Xuanzang (Yuan Chwang) mentioned the learned Brahmin grammarian of this village in the seventh century. Thus a tradition was maintained both before and after him.

The Jain Bhagavatī Sūtra offers a salutation to this Brahmi script.

The Pañcaviṃśa Brāhmaṇa mentions a minimum sacrificial gift of twelve kṛṣṇalas and a maximum of 393,016 kṛṣṇalas of gold.

Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra directs that training in letters and numbers should begin after the cūḍākarman ceremony. It discusses the king's correspondence with his council of ministers and the transmission of coded messages by spies. The Arthaśāstra says that scribes should be skilled in writing rapidly, should write clearly, and should also be capable of reading a written document.

The Buddhist Suttanta mentions the game of akkharikā, a contest in which letters are formed in the air. Buddhist monks are prohibited from taking part in this game, but the Vinaya Piṭaka allows them to learn the art of writing. The Kaṭāha Jātaka speaks of deception by means of a forged letter, while in the Mahāsutasoma Jātaka a teacher at Taxila writes to a former student. The Kaṇha Jātaka uses akkhara, the Pali–Prakrit form of

'letter'. The Mahāvagga refers to instruction in numerals and words, while the Kaṭāha Jātaka mentions the smooth writing-board on which writing was taught. The Lalitavistara describes the Buddha's school of letters, his teacher Viśvāmitra, a sandalwood writing-board and a golden stylus. It describes sixty-four scripts, including, according to political boundaries, those of Aṅga, Magadha and Vaṅga; but instead of a script of Videha, it records the script of Eastern Videha. The reason given is that the Vajji had taken possession of Videha, and the scripts of Vajji and Videha together were known as the Videha script. Ajātaśatru conquered the Vajji in the third century and incorporated them politically into Magadha, but they preserved their cultural identity. The Lalitavistara is a work of the third century; therefore, alongside the Magadha script, it describes the script of Eastern Videha. This tendency became more firmly established later in the Gupta-period province of Tīrabhukti (Tirhut), and the Eastern Videha script acquired the name Tirhuta. The Lalitavistara also describes the young Siddhārtha's training in the alphabet and the arrangement of the lustre and ornamentation of alphabetic letters, which are features of the Brahmi script.

There are remarkable similarities between the northern Semitic alphabet and Brahmi: aleph and अ, beth and ब्, gimel and ग, daleth and द, he and ह, waw and व, zayin and ज, heth and घ, teth and थ, yodh and य, kaph and क, lamedh and ल, mem and म, nun and न, samekh and स, ayin and ए, pe and प, sadhe and च, and qoph and ख. These similarities indicate how the human mind can work alike even across great distances. Bühler was misled into believing that Brahmi had imitated the northern Semitic script. This was the period in which Harappa and Mohenjo-daro were also regarded as outposts of Mesopotamia, until excavations elsewhere in India revealed the indigenous character of Harappan culture (Hermann Kulke and Dietmar Rothermund, A History of India, 2004, p. 19). Yet on page 54 they remain under the misconception that Kharoshthi developed from Aramaic, then the official script of Persia. Aramaic has only twenty-two letters, lacks a complete representation of vowels, does not distinguish short and long vowels, and has no vowel-mātrās; it is therefore unsuitable for Indian languages. Kharoshthi has all these features, together with differentiating signs for the guṇa and vṛddhi grades of vowels. It was as capable as Brahmi of recording Prakrit inscriptions. Merely being written from right to left does not make it foreign. Kharoshthi proceeds from right to left, but its alphabet is Indian. Some scholars detect Persian influence because of its direction of writing; the fact remains that Brahmi and Kharoshthi employed the same alphabet.

In music, the seven notes of Indian sa-re-ga-ma and the seven notes of the Western octave—the word 'octave' merely indicating that the sequence recommences with the eighth—show that, whatever the language, the human ear is the same. Braille and the International Phonetic Alphabet likewise provide evidence of a broadly common communication of sound and mind (Braille); see the appendix. At first some scholars considered Kharoshthi a foreign script and called it Bactro-Pali or Ariano-Pali. Cunningham called it Gandhari. But the testimony of the Lalitavistara and the Chinese encyclopaedia Fa-wang-shu-lin was decisive, and the name given there, Kharoshthi, became generally accepted. Chinese testimony attributes the creation of Brahmi to Brahmā, and the creation of Kharoshthi to the Brahmin teacher Kharoṣṭha. After the third century, inscriptions began to be written in Sanskrit, and the use of Prakrit ceased. Both Brahmi and Kharoshthi could serve Prakrit; but for Sanskrit, with its elaborate and complex words, compounds, inflections and sandhi, only Brahmi could do so. Once the use of Kharoshthi came to an end, scripts descended from Brahmi began to be used even for the languages derived from Prakrit.

Besides Brahmi, the Lalitavistara mentions sixty-three other scripts. Throughout Europe, apart from Greece and the Russian Commonwealth, where different scripts are used, the Roman script is employed. Thus Europe today has only three scripts. If Russia is removed from Europe, the situation is comparable to that of India. In India, almost every province has a different script, yet—Tamil apart—the handling of the alpha-syllabic system of letters and conjunct letters is broadly similar in all of them. The reason is simply the late arrival of the printing press.

Brahmi possessed a standard form, as Aśoka's inscriptions demonstrate. In his fourteenth rock edict, Aśoka says that the merits and defects of the lettering are the responsibility of the scribe. This explains the uniformity of the letters and their shapes in Aśoka's inscriptions and also establishes that Brahmi had acquired a standard form by his reign. Whatever differences occur arise from region, individual scribal handwriting, and the variety of writing implements. Judged by present-day standards, even the irregularities introduced by ancient implements when engraving uneven stones, caves and the like strengthen the case for the existence of standard Brahmi. Punctuation did not exist in Sanskrit, and the same tradition continued in Prakrit. Brahmi scribes therefore did not regard grammatical punctuation marks as necessary.

The characteristics of the Kuṭila script inspired several names: the 'acute-angled alphabet' (Bühler, Indian Palaeography, p. 68); the 'nail-headed alphabet' (Tod, Annals of Rajasthan, p. 700); and the Indian designation Siddhamātṛkā, in use in Kashmir and Varanasi (al-Biruni, India, p. 173,

Sachau). The Deval inscription uses the term kuṭilākṣaraṇī. Ādityasena's Afsad stone inscription calls it vikaṭākṣaraṇī. The Vikramāṅkadevacarita mentions Kāyasthas accomplished in the Kuṭila script.

James Prinsep, who deciphered Aśoka's inscriptions in 1837 CE, recommended the name Kuṭila script (Journal of the Asiatic Society of Bengal, Part V, p. 778).

What caused the development of Kuṭila? First, the use of reed pens and ink, together with new implements and new applications of older ones, created a desire for ornamental inscriptional writing. A preference for cursive handwriting also contributed. The upper parts of letters became hood-like because the ink spread, and tails and lower strokes became more pronounced. Ornamentation gradually gave the characters rounded and smooth forms. It was because of such ornamentation that the script acquired the name Siddhamātṛkā.

Inscriptions in the Kuṭila script have been found on a clay lamp-stand with seven lamps at Kauśāmbī (reminiscent of the Buddhist seven-syllabled cipher of the Mauryan period, associated with a well-known mantra); Yaśodharman's inscription at Mandsaur; Īśānavarman's Haraha stone inscription; Sarvavarman's Asirgarh seal inscription; Anantavarman's Barabar and Nagarjuni cave inscriptions; Īśvaravarman's Jaunpur stone inscription; the inscription on the image at Shahpur; the Mandagiri inscription; the Devavarnark pillar inscription of Jīvitagupta II; Harṣavardhana's Madhuban and Banskhera copperplate inscriptions; and Harṣavardhana's Sonipat seal inscription.

The Limbu language and others were written in the Kirat script. These scripts are written from left to right, but the coded characters of Rañjanā script are written from top to bottom. Nandinagari, a form of Nagari, was used principally in the central Deccan and southern India; Sanskrit manuscripts of Madhvācārya's philosophy of dualism are written in Nandinagari.

Following the model of writing, sign language for deaf people was devised in the eighteenth century CE (Common Era) by Charles-Michel de l'Épée of France in a school for deaf pupils. It is a form of writing created not on paper but in the air, in the surrounding space. Louis Braille of France invented the Braille script for blind people in the nineteenth century. In the twentieth century, Raghunath Murmu invented the Ol Chiki script for the Santali language.

The principal inscriptions of the eastern variety of Brahmi include the Prayag praśasti of Samudragupta, composed by Hariṣeṇa and inscribed on Aśoka's pillar; the Udayagiri cave inscription of Chandragupta II;

Skandagupta's Kahaum pillar inscription; and the Garhwa inscriptions of Chandragupta II and Kumaragupta I.

In tracing the Tirhuta script, we shall move from the northern and southern divisions to northern India, and then from northern India towards the northeast. The distinction between the scripts of northern and southern India can be discerned in the letter म. The distinction between the eastern and western varieties within northern India can be observed in श, ष, ल and ह.

In the eastern variety of Gupta-period inscriptions, the left limb of ल slopes straight downwards (as, for example, in the separate inscription at Jaugada). The base of ष was made round, and its middle sign became garland-like. The base sign of ह was pushed aside, and its curved portion was joined to the vertical stroke.

Although Skandagupta's Bhitari pillar inscription is located in eastern India, it employs the western variety of northern Indian writing. Perhaps the artisan came from the west. Another consideration is that the boundary between the eastern and western varieties of northern Brahmi kept changing. The Rāṣṭrakūṭas, Gurjara-Pratīhāras and Pālas struggled for control of Kanauj approximately between 750 and 1200 CE. Whenever the Gurjara-Pratīhāras prevailed in these alternating wars, the work of western scribes and artists extended eastwards. Similarly, whenever the Pālas gained the upper hand, eastern artisans found employment farther west. Western Brahmi developed into Nagari, while eastern Brahmi developed into Tirhuta, Assamese, Bengali and Odia. The western limit of the eastern variety was set by the Pāla kingdom, Magadha, and Videha together with Vajji. By the tenth century, the eastern limit of Nagari had become Banaras, and Nagari had diverged completely from eastern Brahmi.

Consider Mithila's Karṇāṭa dynasty. In Jyotiriśvara Ṭhākura's Varṇaratnākara, Harasiṃhadeva appears as a nāyaka or king. Born in 1294 CE, he ascended the throne in 1307. After defeat by Ghiyāth al-Dīn Tughlaq in 1324–25, he fled to Nepal. Before that defeat, however, he had tried to establish the Pañjī-prabandha, or genealogical registration system, among Brahmins, Kāyasthas and Kṣatriyas of Mithila. The formally appointed founders were Guṇākara Jha for Maithil Brahmins, Śaṅkaradatta for Karṇa Kāyasthas, and Vijayadatta for Kṣatriyas. Harasiṃhadeva was a descendant of Nānyadeva. In 1326 CE the scholars of Mithila decided to initiate the existing form of the Pañjī-prabandha.

Although Harasiṃhadeva had already left Mithila by then, he was symbolically acknowledged as its founder.

Brahmi thus developed into northern and southern varieties. The northern variety split further into eastern and western forms, and by approximately the tenth century the eastern script had become entirely distinct from the western one. The area of the eastern script came to comprise Magadha, Aṅga and Tirhut. Nagari, the western form of Brahmi, had been confined to the region west of Prayag until the fall of the Gupta empire, but by the eighth century it had reached Varanasi. In the twelfth century both western and eastern types were used in Magadha south of the Ganges. Farther east than Magadha, however, only the eastern type survived south of the Ganges; in Tirhut to the north of the river, likewise, only the eastern type remained. After the Muslim invasions, the western type spread throughout Magadha; but until the fourteenth century the eastern script had not altogether ceased to be used there, as the Mahabodhi Temple at Gaya exemplifies.

The writing of the Pañjī registers began in 1326 CE, and from that time until the twentieth century they continued to be written in Tirhuta without change. The same form ultimately became the basis of the font. (See, on Google Books, the Videha Archive's 11,000 palm-leaf and basah-paper Pañjī records, covering the period from the beginning to the twentieth century; by the end of the twentieth century even the Pañjī began to be written in Devanagari.) The dividing line in Tirhuta's origin and development is therefore 1326 CE, when its definitive form was established. Variations between better and poorer handwriting among the genealogical registrars may be treated simply as different designs of the Tirhuta font.

After Maithili was included in the Eighth Schedule, the central government permitted only Devanagari for Maithili in Union Public Service Commission examinations and official business. Earlier, Sanskrit was written in Devanagari, Tirhuta, Bengali, Tamil and other scripts; now the government has ordered Sanskrit to be written only in Devanagari. In Bihar, Jharkhand and elsewhere, however, one may still symbolically write Maithili in either Devanagari or Tirhuta for school and college examinations and in examinations of the Bihar Public Service Commission. For Union Public Service Commission examinations and other central-government purposes, the government has prescribed Devanagari for Sanskrit, Hindi, Maithili, Marathi, Konkani, Dogri, Bodo and Nepali; Ol Chiki or Devanagari for Santali; Arabic or Devanagari for Sindhi; Persian script for Urdu and Kashmiri; and Bengali script for Manipuri and Bengali. Assamese, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Odia,

Tamil and Telugu are to be written in their respective eponymous scripts, and Punjabi in Gurmukhi.

Let us now return to the development of Tirhuta. Until the fall of the Gupta Empire, the western limit of the eastern variety of the script lay around the region of Prayag; by the eighth century this variety had reached Kashi. From the twelfth to the fourteenth century the eastern variety remained in use in Magadha; thereafter only Nagari was current in that region. In the fourteenth century, the writing of the genealogical registers (*panji*) began in 1326. Following the Muslim invasions, the development of Tirhuta came to a complete standstill, and the script remained, until the twentieth century, essentially in the form it had assumed at that time.

The north-eastern variety possesses certain distinctive features. A new form of "ख" (*kha*) is encountered. In an inscription at Bodh Gaya the base of "ख" has a triangular shape. In the post-Ashokan, or later Mauryan, period, the letter "च" (*ca*) has two curling forms on either side of a vertical stroke; but the two curves are unequal, one small and the other large, and therefore do not make a circle. In the inscriptions on the railings surrounding the Mahabodhi Temple, along the path of circumambulation of the Buddha, "य" (*ya*) and "ज" (*ja*) are of the northern Indian variety, while "ल" (*la*) is sinuous. The inscription on the detached stone at Jaugada, however, is written in an extremely sinuous manner, a characteristic that becomes more pronounced in the eastern variety of early Gupta inscriptions (fourth–fifth centuries). The sinuous form of "ह" (*ha*) found at Jaugada is also seen subsequently in the eastern variety.

Dasharatha's Nagarjuni cave inscription belongs to the north-eastern variety; the same characteristic subsequently appears in inscriptions on the pillars of the circumambulatory railing at the Mahabodhi Temple.

The sinuous "ल" of the Nagarjuni cave inscription deserves attention. Its "श" (*śa*) resembles the form in the Kalsi inscription and is an antecedent of the curled eastern "श" of the fourth and fifth centuries. "स" (*sa*) is also altered: its upper pointed projection becomes longer and bends slightly, taking the appearance of a second stroke.

Inscriptions discovered at Sarnath (from the first century BCE to the first century CE)

The eastern form of the northern Indian variety of Brahmi is found on the stone placed beneath the Mahabodhi tree at Bodh Gaya. The vertical stroke of "प" (*pa*) has become shorter; the triangular lower part of "म"

(*ma*) resembles the pre-Kushan form. "श" is angular, and its horizontal stroke does not touch the vertical line on the left. A sinuous "ह" appears on the Bodhisattva image at Sahet-Mahet, while an angular "ह" occurs elsewhere. The rear part of "स" is broad. "य" is sometimes written as a subscript and has three prongs.

The eastern variety is clearly recognisable in "ल", "ह", "ष" (*ṣa*) and "स". The principal inscriptions of this period are Samudragupta's Prayag pillar panegyric; Chandragupta II's Udayagiri cave inscription; the broken Garhwa inscriptions of Chandragupta II and Kumaragupta I; Kumaragupta I's Dhanaidaha grant; Kumaragupta I's Man Kunwar inscription; Skandagupta's Bihar pillar inscription; the inscription on the image of Bhimavarman at Kosam; and Skandagupta's Kauham pillar inscription.

How are the differences between varieties of script to be identified?

The artistic differences between the northern and southern Indian varieties, including Nagari, can be recognised by looking at the letter "म". Within northern India, the differences between the eastern and western varieties can be identified by examining "ष", "ल" and "ह".

— "य" with three prongs;

— a tendency towards right angles at the base of "घ", "प", "फ", "ष" and "स", together with the absence, in these characters, of the rightward tail or extension that developed in the western variety.

"आ" (*ā*): in the second curve, a semicolon-like opening or separation is joined to the lower part of the right-hand limb.

"उ" (*u*): the horizontal line at the base changed into a curve and grew longer. It remained in this form until the tenth century, when it eventually developed into its final form.

"ख" (*kha*): the base of the character formed a triangle; this subsequently became a straight line and then curved. One side of the triangle turned into a semicircle, while the other lengthened and touched both arcs of the circle.

"ग" (*ga*): curvature in the baseline had begun to appear in the eastern variety from the early Gupta period. In the sixth-century inscription of Yashodharman, the baseline turns towards the left and becomes oblique on the right, making an acute angle with the vertical stroke on the right.

"ज" (*ja*): the horizontal shape of the lower portion had been distinct in the eastern variety since the early Gupta period. Now a pronounced curve appeared in the vertical line as well. The new middle horizontal stroke curved as much as the lower baseline. A V-shaped element was added at the right end of the upper horizontal stroke.

"घ" (*gha*): the curve of its baseline had begun to appear in the eastern variety during the early Gupta period. It now came to resemble the three-pronged "य".

"ण" (*ṇa*): the baseline became oblique, forming an acute angle on the right side of the lower part, while the pointed projection on the left grew longer.

"भ" (*bha*): the distinction between "भ" and "ह्" disappeared; this had already happened in the western variety.

"म" (*ma*): the acute angle became still sharper, with the result that the right-hand limb extended downwards.

"य" (*ya*): two forms are found. The first is two-pronged, with an acute angle in its lower portion. In the second, the acute angle is less distinct, but the right-hand limb extends farther downwards.

"व" (*va*): a change similar to the formation of the triangular base of "ख" is visible here. Both sides of the triangle become curved and the third becomes longer. A V-shaped form appears above the letter.

"ह" (*ha*): the right-hand limb develops a curve and the pointed projection lengthens; a somewhat slanting V-shaped figure appears at the top, while the hitherto horizontal baseline becomes slightly oblique.

Throughout the Afsad inscription, the dental "स" is used.

"श" (*śa*) occurs in three forms. The first is the ancient form, whose upper portion is rounded. The later form lacks a stalk. An intermediate form has a stalk-like element, but this touches the acute angle below instead of joining the vertical stroke on the right.

After Dharmapala, Tirhut remained under Devapala. Thereafter, however, the Gurjara-Pratihara emperor wrested Tirhut away during the reigns of Vigrahapala I and Narayanapala.

"च" (*ca*): the curvature increased.

"ज" (*ja*): in the older form, the middle horizontal line bends slightly downwards, while the lower horizontal line ends in a small curve.

"ट/ठ" (*ṭa/ṭha*): the right-hand limb is not visible.

"भ" (*bha*): bent downwards.

"ष" (*ṣa*): the upper line became oblique.

"स" (*sa*): the baseline became horizontal again, while the upper line bent downwards.

"अ/आ" (*a/ā*): these possess the fully developed Tirhuta form. Even the short line that meets the semicolon-like notch on the right vertical stroke bends downwards.

"त" (*ta*): this has changed. An upper line and a vertical line meet at right angles, while a curve has been added to the left of the vertical line, as in Nagari.

The characteristics of the eastern variety are visible here: "च" has grown thinner; "ज" has become sinuous; "थ" (*tha*) appears to be an early form of the Tirhuta letter; "म" has a hook or loop; in "श", the hook joins the vertical stroke; and in "ष" the upper line slopes downwards. This grant thus presents a mixed form combining eastern and western features.

Some scripts that have not yet been deciphered

(1) The Harappan script.

(3) The Shankha script: its characters resemble conch shells, which accounts for its name. It too was used principally for names and signatures. (Among the three inscriptions found on the Ashokan pillar at Kolhua in Muzaffarpur—the Basarh pillar—some characters belong to the Shankha script.)

(4) A script resembling Brahmi, found on terracotta seals from Chandraketugarh and Tamluk in eastern India.

Some letters acquired their Tirhuta forms earlier, while others did so somewhat later. Certain letters do not occur at all in some inscriptions. Appendix 5 shows the successive stages through which the Tirhuta forms developed. Kaithi, Tibetan and Devanagari likewise reached their present forms through processes of this kind, as shown in the appendix. Some scholars discuss how, after Harshavardhana's time, his minister Arjuna of Tirhut became king of Kannauj and harassed Tibetan Buddhist travellers, and how Tibet, in retaliation, occupied Tirhut. Modern scholars have expressed doubts about this account. Tibetan political domination is doubtful, but the following evidence reveals the cultural presence of Tibetan Vajrayana in Mithila. There are representations of the Buddhist

goddess Tara at Wari in Samastipur and at the Ugratara Temple in Mahishi, Saharsa. Musaharniya Dih is a high mound near Pastan village, three kilometres west of Andhratharhi. Remains of a Buddhist-period single-cell chamber, Buddhist images, coins, fragments of vessels and traces of habitation are found there. A similar Buddhist-period single-cell chamber occurs at the Nahar Bhagwatipur Bhuvaneshwari Temple in Madhubani; it was probably a place of meditation for Buddhist monks. The Buddhist siddha Sarahapada writes: "सिद्धिरत्थु मइ पढमे पढिअउ, मण्ड पिबन्तों बिसरउ एमइउ।" He refers both to *siddhirastu* and to the notion that drinking *māṇḍ*—rice-water—dulls the intellect. From this the author finds evidence that the Buddhist Sarahapada was a Maithil. In the portrait of him obtained from Tibet, the description below his picture is written in Tibetan script.

The Andhratharhi inscription (Shridharadas's Andhratharhi inscription) in Madhubani; the inscription on the Buddha image at Korthu; the inscription on the Vishnu image at Ladho; the twelfth-century Tirhuta inscription on stone at Simraungarh; the nineteenth-century Brahmapura stone inscription, which displays an exemplary form of Tirhuta; Gaurishankar Sthan between the villages of Jamthari and Hainthi Bali in Madhubani district, where an image combining Gauri and Shankara bears a Pala-dynasty inscription in Mithilakshara; and the Tirhuta inscription of the period of Maharaja Madhav Singh, who established the Shiva shrine at Bideshwar near Lohna Road railway station in Madhubani district—all provide evidence. At Mandar Hill in Banka there is a seventh-century inscription in Tirhuta from the Gupta period. According to a Puranic narrative, Mandar was used to churn the ocean. Nearby, at Bounsi, are two images of Vasupujya Nath, the twelfth Jain Tirthankara. The larger image is of red stone, while the other is of bronze, with two footprints in front of it. Vasupujya Nath, the twelfth Jain Tirthankara, was born in Champanagar and attained nirvana here. The Basaiti inscription, near Srinagar in Purnia (Araria district), describes the reign of Rani Indravati, the first woman ruler of Mithila. Madaneshwar Mishra based his novel *Ek Chhalih Maharani* (*There Once Was a Queen*) on this inscription. The Baisi-Basaiti Tirhuta copperplate at Araria records Rani Indravati (1784–1802), who initiated food-for-work and other welfare schemes. Inscribed in Mithilakshara, it has been fastened above a temple, painted black, and made to look like a stone inscription.

In an article published in 2019, Jalaj Kumar Tiwari and S. Krishnamurthy describe the following Tirhuta inscriptions, which, according to them, had not previously appeared in any book. An inscription in Tirhuta script and Sanskrit was found on a Buddha image at Chechar village (Vaishali), dated to the ninth century. An inscription in Tirhuta script and Sanskrit

on a Tara image from Jagatpur Baruary (Supaul), now kept in the Saharsa Museum, dates from the tenth century. Another inscription in Tirhuta and Sanskrit on a Tara image comes from Dabhai Cha (Vaishali), also dated to the tenth century. The inscription on a Vishnu image at Piprauliya in Darbhanga is in Tirhuta and Sanskrit (tenth century). An inscription from Bhachchhi village, near Baheri in Darbhanga district—not Bhachchhi in Madhubani—uses Tirhuta and Sanskrit and dates to the tenth–eleventh century. The stone inscription at Kandaha (Saharsa) was written by the Brahmin Vanshadhar at the command of King Narasimhadeva of the Oinwar period (fifteenth-century Tirhuta script; Sanskrit language). An inscription on an image of Manasa at Bhairavsthan, Muzaffarpur, is in Tirhuta and Sanskrit (fifteenth century). An inscription on a Buddha image from Korthu, Darbhanga, is in Tirhuta and Sanskrit (tenth century). The authors also discuss a first-century Brahmi pillar inscription from Pakhauli village in Vaishali district. Three inscriptions were subsequently carved on the Ashokan pillar found at Kolhua, Muzaffarpur. Two are dated to the seventh century and are in Nagari script and Sanskrit; the third is dated to the fifth century and is in Brahmi script and Sanskrit. Some letters in the three inscriptions on the Ashokan pillar at Kolhua—the Basarh pillar—also belong to the Shankha script and have not yet been deciphered. (Jalaj Kumar Tiwari and S. Krishnamurthy, *Mithila Bharati*, vol. 6, nos. 1–4, 2019.)

We can thus trace the evolution of Tirhuta through the following sequence: the Mauryas in the third century BCE; the Shungas in the second and first centuries BCE; the Shakas and Kushanas from the first to the third century; the Guptas from the fourth to the sixth century; Siddhamatrika from the seventh to the ninth century; and Tirhuta thereafter. Contributions from Tantra and the influence of Tibetan script gave Tirhuta an ornamental character. In *Mithilakshar ka Udbhav aur Vikas* (*The Origin and Development of Mithilakshara*), Rajeshwar Jha could not detach himself from certain old suppositions. For instance, he could not clarify the claim that the script was used as *Brahmi* by grammarians before Panini, that its form was corrupted in Panini's grammar, and that from that point its name became Brahmi. He insists instead that the name Brahmi arose because the script was used by Brahmins. His proposition that Brāhmī—which he writes as *Brahmī*—emerged from the Vaidehī script is also misleading. In Mithila, small inscriptions in the Shankha script have been found, as mentioned above. Like the Harappan script, these have not been deciphered, while inscriptions in Brahmi have also been found. Consequently his assertion that people came directly from Harappa to Videha with Videgha Mathava, as described in the *Shatapatha Brahmana*, and introduced the Vaidehi script here, is not acceptable. The practice found elsewhere in India—

writing longer inscriptions in Brahmi but using the Shankha script for names and signatures—is also found in Mithila. Rajeshwar Jha has likewise exaggerated the influence of Tantric doctrine on the Tirhuta script. Tantra did have an influence, in part directly and in part through Tibetan script, but its effect was to ornament Tirhuta. His statement that the writing method given in the *Shabdakalpadruma* can be used only for Mithilakshara (Tirhuta) and not for Bengali is similarly misleading. Bengali, Mithilakshara, Tibetan and Devanagari all derive from Brahmi. To understand this, one may consider the wide variety of Roman-script fonts: one may resemble Arabic, another may be cursive, yet the texts are convertible from one font to another. The method described in the *Shabdakalpadruma* was applicable not only to Tirhuta but also to Bengali. With the advent of printing, Roman letters largely dispensed with ligatures; in the same way Bengali abandoned many conjunct characters. Rajeshwar Jha erred in associating this newer printed form with the method given in the *Shabdakalpadruma*. He is also mistaken about the Kharoshthi script. Kharoshthi was written from right to left, but it was entirely an Indian script, possessing the same vowels and consonants, including the series beginning *ka, ca, ṭa, ta,* and *pa*. Because it had fewer signs than Brahmi, when inscriptions began to be written in Sanskrit rather than Prakrit, Kharoshthi became unsuitable for writing the compound-heavy inscriptions of Sanskrit and disappeared. No Indian script subsequently developed from it.

The development of the modern Tirhuta form can be followed through Narayanapala's Bhagalpur copperplate grant, Shrichandra's Rampal grant, Mahipala I's Bangarh grant, Bhojavarman's Belwa grant, and Lakshmanasena's Tarpan Nidhi grant, reaching its culmination in the *Vishnupurana* written by Pakshadhar Mishra and the genealogical registers of Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas preserved from 1326 CE onward. Minor differences caused by the individual hands of scribes disappeared with the arrival of printing. Ramlochan Sharan (1889–1971) began publishing Maithili in Tirhuta. Later, computer fonts brought greater uniformity; this became possible through the use of Devanagari Unicode (Mangal), Bengali Unicode (Vrinda), and subsequently Tirhuta Unicode as bases. Letterpress printing presented difficulties, requiring certain shapes to be abandoned. It was sometimes argued that learning this printed Tirhuta would not enable a reader to decipher manuscripts. With computer fonts, different fonts built upon the same underlying encoding can represent different handwriting styles and can be converted into one another. It has therefore become possible to accommodate all the varieties appearing after 1326, including conjunct letters: these were not changes in the script itself, but different styles of writing.

Comparative Study: Maithili and the Neighbouring Indo-Aryan and Austroasiatic Languages

Phonology, morphological patterns and original-language comparative evidence

The vowel pronounced as “a” in Maithili is pronounced as “ā” in Assamese. The Assamese vowel “a” has no corresponding pronunciation in Maithili.

Assamese “ca” and “cha” are pronounced like the Maithili “sa”. Assamese “ja”, “jha”, and “ya” are pronounced like Maithili “ja”; in many Maithili contexts, too, “ya” is pronounced like “ja”.

In Assamese, both retroflex and dental consonants are pronounced as alveolar sounds.

For ṭa, ṭha, ḍa, ḍha, ṇa, ta, tha, da, dha, and na, there is no difference of pronunciation: all are pronounced as alveolars.

Śa, ṣa, and sa are all pronounced like “sa”. In Maithili, “ṣa” is sometimes pronounced like “kha”, whereas “śa” and “sa” are generally both pronounced like “sa”.

When śa, ṣa, and sa appear with “ra” or between two vowels, Assamese also has a third manner of pronunciation without a precise counterpart in Maithili.

In Assamese, a word ending in a conjunct consonant is pronounced with a final inherent vowel. The letter “ña” is pronounced like “na”.

Maithili–Assamese Vocabulary

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Assamese
ऐ (अइ)	एइ
चाह	साह
हमर	मोर
कनियाँ	परिवार
परिवार	संसार
बहीन	मनी
जलखै/जलपान	जलपान

Maithili	Assamese
दही	दोइ
नारिकेलक लड्डू (लड़ू)	नारिकलर लारू
सुआद (सोआद)	सोआद
नीक (भल)	भाल
बेस (बड्ड)	बेस
खाउ	खाओक
लिअ	लओक
जाउ	जाओक
करू	करक
अपने	आपुनि
करबाक/करू (करक)	करक
जएबाक (जाउ)	जाओक
अहाँ	आहा
धानक	धानर
दिअ	दियक
दे	दे
बाड़ीमे	बाड़ीत
औषध	औसध
नेबू (नेबो)	नेमु
कथा (गप)	कथा
एक बेर	एबार
दुइ	दुइ
चारि	सारि
मते (अनुसारे)	मते
लगाति	लगत
खेनाइ	खा
तूँ (पुरातन-तोइ)	तोइ
आइ-काल्हि	आजिकालि

Maithili	Assamese
करह	कर्अ
कतऽ	कोत
नहि (नइँ)	नाइ
चाहक पात	साह पात
बाँस	बाँह
नोकसान	लोकसान
बौस्तु	बस्तु
आनौं (आनी)	आनौं
करौं (करी)	करौं
लिखौं (लिखू)	लिखौं
एक बेर	एबार
आबह	आह
टाका-पाइ (पइसा)	टका-पइसा
के	कोन
परिवार	परियाल
छौरा	लोरा
रखलौं	राखिसों
◌ृाति	राति
बजे	बजात
प्रायः	प्राय
भाराक घर	भाराघर
डेढ़ हजार	डेर हेजार
बेसी	बेसि
पचास	पसास
हाथी	हाँती
हरिण	हरिणा
पोखरि	पुखुरि

Assamese adds the particle -he to emphasise a word. The suffix -janī marks the feminine and -jan marks the masculine.

Assamese uses three kinds of plural marking: -lok with pronouns such as tumi, teõ, and āpuni; -bor with nouns carrying a familiar or depreciative sense; and -hāt with pronouns such as toi, si, ei, and tāi and with certain relational nouns.

Assamese Singular and Plural

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Singular	Plural
तुमि	तोमालोक
आपुनि	आपोनालोक
तेओ	तेओंलोक
तइ	तहँत
सि	सिहँत
एइ	एइहँत
ताइ	ताइहँत/सिहँत
लोरा	लोराबोर
किताप	कितापबोर
घर	घरबोर

For “this” or “this one”, Assamese uses ei; for “that” or “that one”, sei. For “will be necessary”, it uses lāgib.

In Assamese questions, -no is attached to the word receiving emphasis. Adding -owā to a verbal root creates an adjective denoting the past.

Adding -ā to a root produces a verbal noun.

To form the passive in Assamese, -ā is added to a verbal root, followed by -hay or -jāy.

Like Maithili, Assamese changes the form of the verb according to tense.

Maithili and Bengali

Maithili–Bengali Vocabulary

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Bengali
अपने	आपनि
नै (नहि)	नय
छी	आछि/छि
काज	काज
इनार	इनार
करै (करैत) छी	कोरेछि
गेल छलौं (छलहुँ)	गियेछिलाम
बाजू नै	बोलबेन ना
रान्हल	रान्ना
की	कि
संगे	शंगे
चाह	चा
दू टा	दुटो
ई सब	एशब
सिंघाड़ा	शिङाड़ा
कोन	कोन
हाथ	हात
अखन	ऐखोन
पाँचटा	पाँचटा
अच्छा	आच्छा
छथि	आछेन
छी	आछि
हुअय	आछो
करू	कोरून
चाही	चाइ
खोलै छी	खुलछि
कोनो	कोनो

Bengali “a” is pronounced like “o”, as in Odia.

As in Maithili, there is no consistent short–long distinction in the pronunciations of i/ī and u/ū. The vowel ai is pronounced as a+i in Maithili, but as o+ī in Bengali. Bengali au is pronounced as o+u.

Bengali pronounces “na” and “ṇa” alike. In Maithili, “ṇa” is sometimes pronounced as “ṛa”; for example, Gaṇeś becomes Gaṛes.

The letters va and ba alike are pronounced as “ba”, as they often are in Maithili.

Maithili writes and pronounces the month Āśvin as Āsin, whereas Bengali writes Āśvin but pronounces it Āśśin.

Thus:

Bengali: Written and Spoken Forms (I)

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Bengali spelling	Bengali pronunciation
अन्वेषण	अन्नेशन
श्वास	शाश
उच्छ्वास	उच्छास
अक्षर	अक्खोर
पद्म	पद्दो
विस्मय	बिश्शय
उज्जवल	उज्जल

Bengali also has the following differences between spelling and speech:

Bengali: Written and Spoken Forms (II)

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Bengali spelling	Bengali pronunciation
संस्हा	शंस्था
स्हान	स्थान
सुस्ह्	शुस्थो
असुस्ह्	अशुस्थो

In Bengali the particle -to is attached to a word for special emphasis.

A noun or pronoun referring to a previously identified object takes -ṭā or -ṭi in the singular, and -gulo or -guli in the plural.

Numerals may take the suffixes -ṭā, -ṭi, -ṭe, or -ṭo, but not -gulo or -guli.

Relational or genitive forms are used with expressions equivalent to “with” and “for”, as follows:

Cāyer śaṅge — with tea.

Āmār śaṅge — with me.

Āmār jonye — for me.

In Bengali, the oblique form of a pronoun takes -der to form a relational or possessive form.

Āmā → āmāder — my / our.

Āpanā → āpanāder — yours (respectful).

Tomā → tomāder — yours (familiar).

Enā → enāder — theirs / his or her (honorific, according to context).

The particle -nā is placed after a present-tense imperative for emphasis.

Maithili dekhu ne corresponds to Bengali dekhun nā (“do look”).

Maithili uses gemination plus the vowel e to stress a word, as in kamme and ekke. Bengali attains a comparable effect with -i, as in kami.

The negative of Maithili achi (“is”) is nahi achi; the negative of Bengali āche is simply nei.

In the imperfective tense, a vowel-final root takes -cch after its oblique form, whereas a consonant-final root takes -ch. A personal ending is then added after the tense marker.

Maithili–Bengali Verbal and Lexical Forms

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Bengali
हम अबै छी	আমি ফিরিছি
हम जाइ छी	আমি জাচ্ছি
ओ सब आबै छथि	উনি ফিরছেন
अहाँ जाइ छी	আপনি জাচ্ছেন
तूँ आबै छँ	তুমি ফিরছো

Maithili	Bengali
तूँ जाइ छैं	तुमि जाच्छो
ओ सब अबैत छथि	तिनि फिरछेन
ओ सब जाइ छथि	तिनि जाच्छेन
ओ आबै छथि	शे फिरछे
ओ जाइ छथि	शे जाच्छे
अहाँ अबैत छी	आपनि फिरछेन
अहाँ करैत छी	आपनि कोरछेन

Bengali has a kind of non-finite verb formed by adding -te to the oblique form of a verbal root.

Karay me — korte (kor + te), “to do”.

Jāy me — jete (jā + te), “to go”.

Ābay me — āśte (āś + te), “to come”.

Like Maithili, Bengali uses o, ār, and ebaṁ to join words and clauses; Maithili also uses ebaṁ / evam. Bengali o can additionally mean “with”.

Hamhū́— āmi o (“I too”).

The ordinary present-tense form is made by adding a personal suffix to the verbal root.

Kar + i = kori.

Kar + en = karen.

Kar + o = karo.

Kar + iś = koriś.

Kar + e = kare.

Maithili and Bhojpuri

In Bhojpuri:

Bhojpuri Sound Correspondences

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Replaced form	Bhojpuri form
ण	न
ल	र

Replaced form	Bhojpuri form
ष	ख
श	स

Bhojpuri uses companion or paired words of four kinds: antonymic, synonymous, alliterative, and pairs conveying a special sense.

Antonymic companion words

Bhojpuri Antonymic Companion Words

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Word	Antonymic companion
हकासल	पियासल
लरम	गरम
रकम	पताई
साँप	गोजर

Synonymous companion words

Bhojpuri Synonymous Companion Words

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Word	Synonymous companion
लकड़ी	काठी
कनिया	बहरिया
पुरखा	पुरनिया
किन	बेसाह
बिआ	बाल
नेग	चार

Alliterative companion words

Bhojpuri Alliterative Companion Words

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Word	Alliterative companion
अखोर	बखोर
हरवा	हथियार
बोहनी	बट्टा
पर	पाहुन
चासा	बासा
चिरई	चुरुंग

Companion words with special meanings

Bhojpuri Companion Words with Special Meanings

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Word	Special-sense companion
सेवा	खरचा
अह	जह
तगड़	बगड़
अकट	बहेर
आउँज	गाउँज

Some Bhojpuri prefixes

ni-: nidardī (“merciless”).

ku-: kuanna (“bad grain/food”).

adh-: adhamaru (“half-dead”).

Some Bhojpuri suffixes

-ākā / -ait: ḍākā → ḍakait (“dacoit”).

-hār: cūṛī → cūṛīhār (“bangle-maker/seller”).

-hār: lakṛī → lakṛīhār (“one associated with firewood”).

-har: mus → musahar (the community name).

bāp → bahar.

māmā → mamahar.

Bhojpuri: adjectives derived from nouns

Kātik → katikā.

-āin: dhuā́ → dhuāĩn (“smoky”).

Bhojpuri: nouns derived from adjectives

Piyar → piarī.

-aī: thethar → thetharaī.

-autī: būṛh → būṛhautī (“old age”).

Bhojpuri: nouns derived from nouns

-aī: larikā → larikāī (“childhood”).

Bhojpuri: adjectives derived from adjectives

Lāl → lalchahū́

-authā: pahil → pahilauthā (“first-born”).

Feminine suffixes

-āin: Misir → Misarāin.

-ānī: devar → devarānī (“the wife of a younger brother-in-law”).

Number in Bhojpuri

Laikā (singular) → laikan (plural).

Hāthī (singular) → hāthin / hāthiyan (plural).

Maithili–Bhojpuri Forms

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Bhojpuri
छथि	तारी
खाइत अछि	खाता
खुजैत अछि	खुलता
नहि खेलाइत छथि	खेलत नइखन
नहि अछि	नइखे
नहि जयताह	ना जइहन
नहि खयताह	ना खइहन
जाइ छी	जातार
पढ़ैत छी	पढ़ तानी

Maithili	Bhojpuri
खाइ छथि	खा तारन
अहाँ	रउआ

Bhojpuri itself has regional variants, including bā, bāṭe, bīyā, baṛvẽ, baṭe, and bānī.

Maithili and Magahi

Bhuvaneshwar Sharma's Magahi dictionary omits certain letters and conjuncts, including ṇa, śa, ṣa, ṛ, ḷ, kṣa, tra, and jña. As in Maithili, Magahi often pronounces va as ba and ya as ja.

Magahi likewise traces its origins to the Nāth literature of the eighty-four Siddhas and the Nāth tradition. Its verbs may have one fewer ā vowel-mātrā, as illustrated below:

Maithili–Magahi Forms (I)

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Magahi
एनाइ	अनई
गेनाइ	गनई
धोनाइ	धोनई

Magahi proverbs and sayings

"Adrā gel, tīn gelan, san, sāṭhī, kapās": without rain during the Ārdrā constellation, cultivation of san, sāṭhī rice and cotton fails.

"Ochā ke prīt bālū ke bhīt": friendship with an ignoble person is as short-lived as a wall of sand.

"Btāt deval": to provide subsistence or expenses.

"Siharī phaṭal": one's savings or resources were exhausted.

"Hahās kayal": to burn with envy when another person advances.

"Tulā rāśi ke bhel": to become very angry.

"Kanyā rāśi ke bhel": to become incapable of doing work.

"Orhan deval": to make a complaint.

"Pīṛhā deval": to show respect.

"Khopasan deval": to reproach or accuse.

Dr Ramnaresh Mishra "Hans" calls Magahi the developed form of the speech of Magadha. Assamese, Bengali, Odia, Maithili, Bhojpuri and other languages also developed from Magadhi Prakrit.

Magahi uses la and ṛa in place of ra, and ra and ṛa in place of la. It also forms words with the prefix nir-, as in niraith (from aith / niraith).

Magahi folk epics and ballads

Ālhā, Sorṭhī Vrajbhār, Lorakāin, Resmā–Cuharmal, Sāraṅgā–Sadāvṛj, Chatrī–Ghughuliyā, Kũvar Vijayī, Rājā Bharatharī, Gopīcand, Sobhā˜ Nāyak, Satī Bihulā, Neṭuā Dayāl Siṅgh, Rājā Ḍholan Siṅgh, Mān Gujariyā, Māmā–Bhaginā, Vikram, Kardab-līlā, Bañjārā, Hirnī–Birnī, Sahles, Nūnācār, Rājā Harican, Bābā Cintāman, Baktour, Bihulā–Vishaharī, and Bābā Lakhandar Bihulā–Viṣadhar.

Magahi folk drama, dramatic songs and dances

Kīrtan, jātrā, Karmā Bhaiyā Dūj, Jītiyā (a heroine goes angrily to her parental home; farm workers stage this drama after planting rice).

Phāgū, Caitā, Sāvanī, Bārahmāsā, and Ropnī.

The dramatic songs of the Dūdhvaṃśī (Dusadh), Sāfī (Dhobi), Candra-vaṃśī (Kahar), and Koiri communities.

Women's and caste-linked performances: Domkac, Bīchāmār, Culhārin, Sītā–Mītā, Gedurī.

Ojha–Ḍāin.

Sāmā–Cākevā, Bagulā–Bagulī, Jāṭ–Jāṭin, and Sās–Putoh.

Sagbecnī, Machlī Becnī, Jīrābun, and Dahī Becnī.

Dance, Neṭuā–Kasbin, and puppet theatre.

Let us now consider some Maithili forms and their Magahi equivalents.

Maithili–Magahi Forms (II)

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Magahi
खेलेलौं (खेलेलहुँ)	खेलली
हएत	होत
अछि	हे
छथि	हथ/हथुन

Maithili	Magahi
छी	ही
जायत	जइतो
एता	अतथुन
भेटत	मिलतो

Forms used in Magahi

Around Patna one hears forms such as māraluk (mārbau), which change further south into forms such as hathin and chathin.

Maithili and Santali

Maithili–Santali Comparative Vocabulary

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Santali
पिता	बा
बाबी (बा)	नुनुगो (बुडीगो)
बाबा	गोड़म्बा
नमस्ते	जोहारगी
भेल	हुयेना
उसरि कऽ (जल्दी)	उसारा
अछि	काना/गिया
छी	काना
आर	आर
सँ	ते
एखन लगाइत	एहोबोक् लगीत
देखाउ	उदुगमे
विलम्ब	बिलम्ब
दिऔ	मे/में
करू	मा/कामीयमे
नहि	आलोम
बनू	बिनाक्आ

Maithili	Santali
बुरबक (बोका)	बोका
आउ	हजुक्मे
ध्यान	ध्यान
दाँत सभ	डाटा
लगा लिअ	लगाव ताम
सत्त	सरी
खबरि	खोबोर
हमरा	इञ
खराप	बड़ीच्
मोन	मोने
लगा कऽ	लगाव
काज	कातेक
कैं	दो
घास	घास
आनू	अगुकुम
अहाँ सँ	आमसांव
जरूर	जरूड़
थोर	थोड़ा
पंखा	पंखा
बिजली	बिजली
लैम्प	लैम्प
कागत-पेंसिल	कागज-पेंसिल
मना	मना
मामिला	मामला
समय	समय
धन	धन
मेहनति	मेहनत
अहाँ	आम

Maithili	Santali
कुकुड़ (पु.)	सीता
कुकुड़ (स्त्री.)	सीता इंगा
पिल्ला (कुकुड़क बच्चा)	सीता होपोन
बाछी	बछी
बेंग	रोटे
पनही (जुत्ता)	पनाही
करैल	कारला
घर (दलान)	दुलान
मचान	मचान
कड़छु	कड़छु
पटिया	पटया
चालनि	चलनी
सलाइ-काठी	सलाई कठी
सूत	सुतम
थारी-बाटी	थरी-बटी
लोटा	लोटा
बोरा	बोरा
गहूम	गुहुम
दही	दाही
थुथुन	थुथना
गाहकि (गहकी)	गहकी
अखबार	खोबोर कागज
हरियर	हरयड़
खर्चा	खर्चा
साफ करब	साफा
बीछब	बाछाव
बनायब	बिनाव
नव करब	नावा

Maithili	Santali
नेहोरा करब	नेहोर
जिरायब (विश्राम करब)	जिराव
थरथरी	थारथाराक्
आछी करब (छीकब)	अछीम
साटब	साटाव

For the optional Maithili paper in the Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) civil-service examination:

Maithili and Hindi

Maithili–Hindi Vocabulary

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Hindi
हमरा सभक	हमारा
हमर	मेरा
ओकर	उसका
ई	यह
ओ	वह
ई सब	ये
ओ सब	वे
अछि	है
छी	हूँ
देखनाइ	देखना
जीनाइ	जीना
गेनाइ	जाना
पीनाइ	पीना
छूनाइ	छूना
सुतनाइ	सोना
पढ़नाइ	पढ़ना
जाउ	जाइए

Maithili	Hindi
जो	जा
राम गेल	राम गया
सीता गेलि	सीता गई
आननाइ	लाना
बजनाइ	बोलना
बिसरनाइ	भूलना
छह	हो
लिखैत अछि	लिखता है
लिखि रहल अछि	लिख रहा है
जायत	जाएगा
अयताह	आएंगे
राम जाइत अछि	राम जाता है
सीता जाइत अछि	सीता जाती है
सीता जाइत छथि	सीता जाती हैं
राम खेनाइ खेलक	राम ने खाना खाया
राम सोहारी खेलक	राम ने रोटी खाई
तोँ ई काज केने छह	तूने यह काम किया है
राम फिल्म देखने छल	राम ने फिल्म देखी थी
राम फिल्म देखने छला	राम जी (आदर) ने फिल्म देखी थी
राम पाठ समाप्त कऽ लेने होयत	राम ने पाठ समाप्त कर लिया होगा
राम पाठ समाप्त कऽ लेने हेता	राम जी (आदर) ने पाठ समाप्त कर लिया होगा
राम सीताकेँ देखलक	राम ने सीता को देखा
राम सीताकेँ देखलनि	राम जी (आदर) ने सीता को देखा

The tables show that Hindi marks the agent with ne, whereas Maithili has no corresponding marker in these examples. For the object, Hindi uses ko and Maithili uses kẽ.

Illustrations of Hindi and Maithili Number and Case

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Hindi	Maithili	Illustrative lexical form	Illustrative lexical form	Illustrative example
मैथिली	सेब	एकटा सेब	दूटा सेब	दूटा सेबमे
हिन्दी	सिपाही	एक सिपाही	दो सिपाही	दो सिपाहियों ने
मैथिली	सिपाही	एकटा सिपाही	दूटा सिपाही	दूटा सिपाही
हिन्दी	साधु	एक साधु	दो साधु	दो साधुओं को
मैथिली	साधु	एकटा साधु	दूटा साधु	दुनू साधुकेँ
हिन्दी	चमगादड़	एक चमगादड़	दो चमगादड़	दोनों चमगादड़ों पर
मैथिली	बादुर	एकटा बादुर	दूटा बादुर	दुनू बादुर पर
हिन्दी	चिड़िया	एक चिड़िया	दो चिड़िया	दो चिड़ियाओं
मैथिली	चिड़ै	एकटा चिड़ै	दूटा चिड़ै	दुनू चिड़ै

These examples show that Hindi plural inflection changes the form of the word, whereas in Maithili it does not. In a few feminine verbal forms Maithili changes like Hindi (geli); more often, however (jāit achi, chathi), it does not. In honorific sentences, Hindi leaves the verb unchanged in the cited comparison, while Maithili distinguishes dekhlak from dekhlani. Hindi changes forms in the feminine plural, unlike Maithili.

Maithili and Hindi Case Particles

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Case / case particle (Maithili)	Case / case particle (Hindi)
राम	राम ने
रामकेँ	राम को
गेन्दसँ, लाठीसँ, लाठी द्वारा	गेन्द से, लाठी द्वारा
रामकेँ, रामकलेल, राम हेतु	राम को, राम के लिये, राम हेतु
गाछसँ (विलगाव)	पेड़ से
रामक घर, रामक पोथी, सीताक राम	राम का घर, राम की किताब, सीता के राम

Case / case particle (Maithili)	Case / case particle (Hindi)
घर पर, खोतामे	घर पर, घोसला में

Maithili and Odia

The following special observations clarify relations between Maithili and Odia.

Where Maithili uses the written vowel ī, Odia uses ie, though their pronunciations correspond; the difference is chiefly orthographic.

Maithili tū̃jāh corresponds to Odia tū jā; Maithili tū̃jo to Odia tume jāa; and respectful Maithili ahā̃jāū to Odia āpaṇa jāāntu.

Maithili achi ("is") is also achi in Odia.

The old Maithili possessive mor, found in Vidyāpati's phrase piā mor bālak, survives in Odia prose.

Odia nāhĩ / nāī stands for Maithili nahi. Comparable pronunciations occur in Maithili, and its magazine Antikā also prints naĩ. Odia āpaṇa is comparable to Maithili apne / ahā̃.

Odia chi corresponds to Maithili chī.

Odia keũ, kāli, and piilā correspond respectively to Maithili kon, kālhi, and pīlak.

Odia śuṇiluni corresponds to Maithili nai sunalani; the negative particle ni is added at the end in Odia.

Odia -ku corresponds to Maithili -kẽ: Rāmkẽ becomes Rāmku.

The word del ("gave") is the same in both languages.

Where Maithili speaks of rice being sijh ("cooked"), Odia uses sijhāpāṇi for boiling water. Maithili haet corresponds to Odia heb, and nai haet to hebani, where ni makes the negative.

Odia āgaru, karibāku, paṛib, dekhich, kete, and jete correspond to Maithili agrim / agārī, karābay, paṛat, dekhne chah, katek / katte, and jatek / jatte.

Odia se corresponds to Maithili o ("that one"). Maithili se, as in se kahalak, has a somewhat different use, broadly an adverbial sense such as "differently".

Maithili–Odia Vocabulary

The forms in both columns are preserved in the original languages to make the linguistic comparison verifiable.

Maithili	Odia
जाइ छै	जाउछि
एकटा (गोटे)	गोटे
बुलब/बुलनाइ	बुलिबा
दूटा	दिटा
कोन ठाम(कोन ठाँ)	केउँठि
जाइ छी	जाउछि
देखै छी	देखिछि
आउर के	आउ किए
आबैले छथिन्ह	आसिछन्ति
मरि गेल	मरिगला
जाइ छै	जाइछि
जेबै	जिबे
जायब	जिबि
छलै (छलय)	थिला
जैठाम (जइठाम, जइठाँ)	जेउँठि
दरमाहा	दरमा
गेल	गले
बैसा कय	बसेइदइ
करायब	करेइबा
तोहर	तांकर
लागैछै	लागुछि
करबै	करिबेनि
से काज	से काम
करि लेता	करिनेब
किछु	किछि
दऽ देबै	देइदेबि
तऽ (तँ)	त
दिआयल जायत	दिआजिब

Maithili	Odia
भौजी/भाउज	भाउज
जलखै	जळखिआ
आउर (आओर)	आउ
चाह	चा

Odia pronunciation also differs. Its inherent vowel a is often sounded like o: Maithili samar is pronounced somoro in Odia. This affects consonants followed by the inherent vowel. Maithili Manoj may be said Manoj, but Odia has Monojo.

The pairs i/ī and u/ū are pronounced similarly in Maithili and Odia.

The vowels ai and au are articulated as a+i and a+ū, respectively, in Odia as in Maithili.

Maithili ṛ is pronounced like rī, while Odia gives ru: Sanskrit kṛpa is read krīp in Maithili and krupo in Odia.

Both languages sound va as ba; Maithili has "ba", while Odia adds its inherent "o" sound.

In foreign loanwords, however, Odia may pronounce a final consonant without adding the inherent vowel o.

Some instances of ya are pronounced as ja in both languages: Maithili yam is jam and Odia pronounces it jomo.

When ḍa or ḍha occurs at the beginning of a word, the dot beneath the character is omitted in both languages.

Of the fifth nasals in the five consonant classes (ṅa, ña, ṇa, na, ma), both languages ordinarily permit only na and ma at the beginning of a word.

Maithili pronounces kṣa as kcha; Odia uses kha or khya.

Like Marathi, Odia retains Sanskrit ḷa, which is no longer found in Maithili.

Both languages pronounce jña as gya.

The conjunct tsa is pronounced tas in Maithili, but as s + ca in Odia.

25. Agricultural and Fisheries Vocabulary (Based on Fieldwork)

Abstract

A *bhaurī jāl* is used for catching small fish. A *bhirkhā* is lifted by hand and thrown. It is made with thread and iron weights, each weighing 25 grams, with a total weight ranging from approximately 2½ to 5 kilograms.

Keywords: agriculture · fisheries · vocabulary · fieldwork · critical theory · Maithili

Fish are also caught with a fishing line and hook (*vaṃśī*).

For small fish, a *bhaurī jāl* is used.

A *bhirkhā* is raised by hand and thrown. Thread and iron weights are used in it; the weights are approximately 25 grams each, amounting to a total of about 2½ to 5 kilograms. An *antā jāl* is small and is set along the bank at night.

A *koṭhī jāl* is large and incorporates bamboo.

A *bisārī jāl* is used at night. Because the fish would be disturbed and scatter by day, stakes are set at night and the fish are caught then.

A *caṭṭī jāl* is made of plastic and comes in large and small sizes. It is used in the daytime, during both Āṣāḍh and Sāvan, and is lifted after five to ten minutes.

There is a thick-thread *parachute net*; a *current net* made from a combination of thread and nylon; and a large *hāṭā net* made of thread.

Small fish can escape from the parachute net.

Large fish are caught with a large hook and line, a large *caṭṭī jāl*, or a large thread net (*mahājāl*).

Both large and small fish are caught using a bamboo *jaṅghā*. It is fastened with coconut-fibre and nylon cord to a structure standing four hand-lengths high.

Fish are also caught with a rod made from a slender bamboo strip.

Fish are also caught by arranging 100 to 200 bundles of jute stalks together.

A *hāṭā jāl* is made of thread and may extend for as much as a kilometre.

A *cāĉ* is made of *kahrā* bamboo. Fish are caught by enclosing a stream or a flooded channel. The water is stirred and a *ḍagarī* is placed; the *cāĉ* is enclosed with a *fahaṛā*.

Kinds of fish

Ḍāṛā fish (ḍerkā fish), mūṅhā, poṭhī, lattā (piā fish), gaṛaī, palvā, ṭeṅgaṛā, siṅghī, māg̃uṛ, capṛā, painā, revā, gaṛhī, uranthā, mohul, buārī, bāmī, baghār, celvā, kaual, gorrā, saul, bhaurā, kajāl, kalbaus, cittal, bhoi, kattī, bhaukuṛī, silon, rehū, mirkā, bilāskap, silver carp, China māg̃ur, kabaī and China kabaī.

Darbā: small and slender, two to three inches long; black along the back and white at the sides.

Gaṛaī: black.

Copṛā: broad, black and dull-coloured.

Palvā: spines on both sides and on the back; yellowish-white in colour; also has barbels.

Ṭeṅgaṛā: a large fish, also with three spines and barbels around the mouth.

Siṅghī: slender, with two spines on either side; red, or red mixed with light black.

Maṅgurī: thick-bodied and relatively expensive; also has two spines; red and slightly black.

Painā: white, with a spine on its back.

Revā: white; weighing from a quarter to half a kilogram.

Ḍaṛhī: white, with a spine on the back.

Uranthā: white, with a spine on the back and a downward bend beneath.

Bhālu: a long mouth; whitish or yellowish in colour; a spine above and a spine near the navel (as described for fish generally).

Boālī: a wide mouth; up to 20 kilograms in weight; white, with a spine on the back and fins on both sides (as with fish generally).

Bāmī: long-bodied, living in holes; the mouth projects forwards and is round; it is long like a needle, with a spine on the back and two near the navel.

Baghār: found in sizes ranging from about a quarter-kilogram to a quintal; blackish-brown or yellowish; one spine on the back and two on the sides; a broad tail, flattened mouth and considerable breadth.

Celvā: white and without spines; fins on both sides for movement; a particularly swift fish.

Kaual: white, with a long mouth.

Gorrā: barbels resembling a moustache and beard, spines, and a forward part that bends.

Saul: red and yellow, elongated, weighing two, three or five kilograms.

Bhaurā (*gajāl*), *saul*, and spotted varieties: large, weighing 20, 25 or even 40 kilograms; with round white, green and black markings.

Kalbaus: light black in colour.

Andājī fish

Cittal: very broad; 20–25 kilograms in weight, and two to three feet across.

Silon: domesticated or pond-reared, weighing three to four kilograms.

Rohu: yellowish or slightly white, with a spine on the back.

Mirkā: pale reddish-white.

Silver carp: pond-reared.

China māg̃ur: brought in from outside (reared); spines on both sides.

China kabaī: reared and brought in from outside; spines at various places along the back.

Kabaī: spines near the gills and along the back.

Ceṅgā fish: like *kabaī*, it can travel a considerable distance even on dry ground.

Now, some other aquatic creatures:

Saũs (dolphin): eats fish in the water, does not harm people, plays with people, and makes a whistling sound.

Ghariyāl: found in the Ganges near Kursela; a long snout, measuring one to one and a half hand-lengths; finger-like teeth; reddish colouring; and a long tail, with a length of three hand-lengths.

Bõch: described as having a human-like colour and appearance, black in colour, with hair on its head; it catches hold of hair and pulls a person under water.

And now, agricultural vocabulary:

A pair of oxen / the plough (*har*).

Īś: joined to the plough and tied to the *pālo*.

Lagnā.

Pālo: placed on the shoulders.

Two *kanail* pieces on either side of the *pālo* prevent the oxen from moving this way and that.

A cord about one to one and a quarter feet long is tied away from the *kanail*. The cord is tied to the *samail*, a short piece of wood or bamboo about three-quarters of a foot long.

The *peṭār* below the *īś* prevents the *īś* from coming loose, while permitting upward and downward movement.

The plough has a *puṭṭhī*; below it a separate *phallī* of about two feet is fitted into the *puṭṭhī* and breaks up the soil.

Parhat (*lagnā*): the ploughman rests his hand on this. A grip or handle (*muṭhiyā*), measuring three feet / six inches, is fixed into the *lagnā*.

Nādhā: a rope four to five feet long connecting the *pālo* to the *īś* by tying them together.

Two *maiḍor* ropes, each ten to eleven feet long, are tied to the *caukī* and to the oxen; the ploughman uses this arrangement to work the *caukī*.

Caukī: a bamboo or wooden board six to seven feet long. The ploughman stands on it while working it. He holds a *jhūr*, *jvolī* or stick to drive the oxen.

For wheat, the land is ploughed three inches deep, making four or five furrows.

For maize, a depth of four to five inches is required.

Seed: for an acre (100 decimals), two *man* of wheat seed or ten kilograms of maize seed.

Fertiliser: at sowing time, the stated application per acre of wheat is 20 kilograms of DAP, 5 kilograms of potash, 5 kilograms of urea and 5 kilograms of zinc.

In maize cultivation, when the plants reach one and a half to two feet, soil is heaped around them. Two rows are set two feet apart. Two quintals of fertiliser are stated to be applied per acre: 100 kilograms of DAP, 50 kilograms of urea, 20 kilograms of sulphic fertiliser, 120 kilograms of potash and 10 kilograms of zinc. During irrigation, fertiliser is applied,

earth is heaped up and the field irrigated again. After irrigation, one quintal of urea per acre is applied.

Now, varieties of vegetables:

Siṅghiyā karelā: large bitter gourd; *high-break* /plain variety.

Choṭkī karelā: small bitter gourd; *hajariyā* /*julmī*.

Safed karelā: white bitter gourd; *paṭniā* (*najlī*, of medium stem length).

Watermelon:

Nāmdhārī: tasty; red inside, whitish or mottled outside (green and white).

Maiko: slightly black.

Pahujā: darker than *Maiko*.

Rājdhānī: black-coloured.

Mahārājā: large and small, black-coloured.

Sainī and *Sugardībī*: black-coloured.

Nāth: lightly mottled (white and green).

Gaṅgāsāgar: clear white, like a pumpkin.

Soraiyyā: mottled.

Cucumber:

Julmī: small.

Hybrid.

Maiko: long, green and yellow.

Mahārājā: a cucumber variety.

Khetībārī: green, not very long, thicker at the back and narrower at the front.

26. Verbal Testimony, Epistemology and Linguistics

Abstract

The Grammarians; Verbal Testimony (Nyāya): Epistemology and Metaphysics; the Linguist Ramavatar Yadav. According to the grammarians, Śabda-Brahman, or Sphoṭa, is the ultimate reality, and Śabda-Brahman is also the cause of the creation of this universe. Śabda-Brahman has neither beginning nor end; it is present everywhere, is capable of acting of its own accord, and witnesses every event. When the soul realises its unity with this Śabda-Brahman, it is liberated.

Keywords: Word · Pramāṇa · Knowledge · Epistemology · Language · Science · Grammar

Editorial

The Grammarians; Verbal Testimony (Nyāya): Epistemology and Metaphysics; the Linguist Ramavatar Yadav

According to the grammarians, Śabda-Brahman, or Sphoṭa, is the ultimate reality, and Śabda-Brahman is also the cause of the creation of this universe. Śabda-Brahman has neither beginning nor end; it is present everywhere, is capable of acting of its own accord, and witnesses every event. When the soul realises its unity with this Śabda-Brahman, it is liberated.

Śabda-Brahman is a theory of sound, which becomes divided into two parts, word and object, although these two proceed in parallel. Speech is divided into four stages: (1) parā, (2) paśyantī, (3) madhyamā and (4) vaikharī. In the parā state, power and its possessor are completely identical. Time enters at the paśyantī stage, the source of all words and objects. Paśyantī is praṇava (ॐ), also called pratibhā. Paśyantī is the source of all words, and pratibhā of all meanings; yet the two are one, distinguished only for purposes of reasoning. At the madhyamā stage the distinction between word and object can be recognised, and an order among words becomes apparent, although sound is still confined to the mind. At the vaikharī stage words make objects intelligible and are articulated through the throat, teeth, palate, tongue and other organs. In the beginning Śabda-Brahman exists as sat, comprising cit, ānanda, knowledge, desire and action, as well as the power of freedom and time. Then sat wishes to divide itself with the aid of time, and cit and ānanda emerge separately. Knowledge proceeds from cit, and desire from ānanda. Sat thus becomes paśyantī in six modes: sat, cit, ānanda, knowledge, desire and action. In paśyantī, word and object remain exceedingly subtle, intermingled with one another. In madhyamā they become distinguishable, but have not yet

been produced. In vaikharī, however, word and object arise in two distinct streams.

What is the smallest unit of language: the phoneme or letter, the word, or the sentence? Mīmāṃsakas regard the phoneme as the unit of language, Naiyāyikas the word, and the grammarians the sentence.

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi is divided into four parts: (1) perception (direct apprehension); (2) inference; (3) comparison (analogy or resemblance); and (4) word (verbal testimony). These four parts examine the four means of obtaining valid knowledge. Experience is acquired through perception, inference, comparison and verbal testimony. Gaṅgeśa gave comparison its proper place within Nyāya as a method of discovering the meaning of words.

An attempt was therefore made to bind and regulate this language through grammar. Mīmāṃsakas hold that the relation between a word and its meaning has existed from beginningless time: it is not externally created and remains independent. Early Mīmāṃsakas believed in the Vedas but not in God. Buddhists regard language, including the language of the Vedas, as a human imaginative construction, a vikalpa. Jacques Derrida provides a bridge between the Buddhists and the Mīmāṃsakas. He locates the beginning of language in the art of writing, thereby moving away from Nāgārjuna and closer to Bhartṛhari's grammatical thought. Nevertheless, like the Buddhists, Derrida opposes the idealisation of language and favours a subject-oriented approach.

A Comparative Study of Traditional Grammar and Modern Linguistics — Jian Li and Qingming Li [School of Humanities and Foreign Languages, Xi'an University of Technology, Shaanxi, Xi'an, China] [International Conference on Education, Management, Commerce and Society (EMCS 2015), pp. 287–291]

Traditional Grammar

As the oldest form of grammar, traditional grammar is said to have originated in the fifteenth century BCE, with Plato and Aristotle in Greece and the Sanskrit scholar Pāṇini in India. Various Roman and early Christian writers also contributed to traditional grammar, but traditional grammarians began writing most influentially in the eighteenth century, when English came to be treated seriously as a language in its own right rather than merely another vernacular. The characteristics of traditional grammar may be described as follows. First, one of its chief features is that it is generally based on meaning. According to traditional grammar, a sentence is a group of words expressing a complete thought. Traditional grammar commonly begins with meaning and proceeds in analysis from

meaning to form. From the standpoint of language teaching, it does not provide a systematic description of linguistic phenomena. It usually describes language at the surface level, often analysing individual sentences in isolation rather than at the level of discourse. Sometimes even that level of description is absent. Consequently, it gives the teacher no satisfactory account of the language being taught and the learner no adequate description of the language to be learnt. Traditional grammar generally describes written language without examining spoken language. It also confuses written with spoken forms, although, as we know, the spoken system differs to some extent from the written one. Thus it cannot provide students with the system required for oral communication. Traditional grammar assigns a prominent place to morphology and syntax, while its treatment of lexis and phonology is often inadequate. Despite these shortcomings, traditional grammar remains highly valuable for language teaching and school grammar. Many still regard it as a practical, elegant and time-honoured means of teaching people what they need to know about a language.

Modern Linguistics

Modern linguistics begins with the Swiss linguist Ferdinand de Saussure (1857–1913), often called the 'father of modern linguistics' and described as a master of the discipline whose work made it 'modern' (Culler 1976: 7). Modern linguistics is the science of linguistic study. According to its approach, language is a system, and grammar is a systematic description of a particular language, whether written or spoken. Grammar can also mean a distributional analysis of surface-structure elements according to distributional criteria. Modern grammar also takes phonetic and semantic components into account. In general, it is evaluated in terms of present applicability, simplicity, completeness, clarity and freedom from contradiction. Modern grammatical approaches include descriptive grammar, structural grammar, functional grammar, transformational-generative grammar (case grammar), and many others.

Descriptive Grammar: Descriptive grammar explains how a language is actually spoken and written, rather than prescribing how it should be spoken or written. It holds that speech is the primary form of language and that spoken and written language differ. Fries was a distinguished grammarian, and his American English Grammar is a well-known work. He divides words into two categories, content words and function words, rather than the ten separate parts of speech of traditional grammar. Content words are words which undergo inflection and possess lexical meanings, such as nouns, verbs and adjectives. Function words play significant roles in constructing structures, determining relations,

forming subordinate connections, functioning as auxiliaries and expressing emphasis.

Structural Grammar: Structural grammar differs fundamentally from traditional grammar. Rather than concentrating on individual words, their assumed meanings, or their parts-of-speech functions within a sentence, it investigates groups of structures—sounds, forms, word groups and phrases—and the progression from smaller to larger units. Structural grammar also examines meaning, although some of its early advocates attempted to disregard it; its emphasis falls on syntactic patterns rather than isolated lexical meanings. It therefore analyses the meanings conveyed by the patterns that morphemes and words form together: plural formations, modifier–verb or modifier–adjective relations, subject–predicate relations, and the like.

In addition to its general emphasis on morphology and syntax, structural grammar developed three particularly useful analytical techniques: test frames, immediate-constituent analysis and sentence formulas. Test frames have proved especially helpful for teaching grammar in schools.

The disadvantages of structural grammar are as follows:

It offers an incomplete account of a language's grammatical system and does not supply the rules required to generate an unlimited series of grammatical constructions.

It places excessive weight on morphological and morphophonemic rules, while paying little attention to semantic relations, much as traditional grammar does.

It describes the surface structure of sentences and gives inadequate or mistaken accounts of many deeper generalisations.

Structural grammar offers a criterion for determining whether a sentence is grammatical and the degree of its grammaticality, but does not explain matters sufficiently to guarantee clear understanding and correct use. Learners may consequently make errors.

Its treatment does not include meaning; yet without attention to meaning, no grammatical analysis can be useful.

It also fails to provide a satisfactory basis for two other important areas: compositional analysis and translation in applied linguistics.

Transformational-Generative Grammar: Transformational-generative grammar, or TG grammar, was developed by Noam Chomsky. It emerged in 1957, inaugurating a revolution in linguistics. According to some linguists, TG grammar synthesises the contributions of traditional and structural grammar. From structural grammar, Chomsky reworked

immediate-constituent analysis (ICA) as the first stage of his grammar. Yet he proceeded much further, satisfying the demand for precision through successive stages of formalisation: classical theory, standard theory, extended theory and revised extended theory.

In the first stage, represented by Syntactic Structures, the concern is with the infinite set of sentences generated by context-free structures and the formation of basic transformational rules. In the second stage, represented by Aspects of the Theory of Syntax, the original syntactic theory is enlarged into a general theory of grammar that incorporates phonology and semantics. Deep structure provides the syntactic base, while surface structure concerns phenomena such as sounds, word order and thematic patterning. In the extended-theory stage attention shifts from individual grammars to universal grammar. All transformational rules are reduced to a single rule, and a universal formulation of constraints is developed. The advantages of TG grammar are therefore these. First, it genuinely brings syntax, phonology, the lexicon and semantics together, thus providing an integrated conception of language. Its system is more precise and more complete than other grammatical models. Second, it offers a more economical and systematic account of language: a system of rules capable of generating infinitely many grammatical sentences. Unlike traditional grammar, the rules stated by TG grammar are both explicit and formally defined. Third, it demonstrates considerable powers of generalisation. It can make clear underlying structures and regularities that traditional and structural grammarians have neglected. Fourth, it recognises linguistic universals across languages and allows analysis at the level of deep structure. Structural grammar assumes that every language possesses an individual structure. TG grammar, on the contrary, recognises common general forms and kinds of rules in the description of all languages. This concerns formal universals. It also proposes common categories and deep structures, relating to substantive universals. Finally, TG grammar can identify grammaticality and degrees of grammaticality, which are indispensable to evaluation, testing and error analysis.

Functional Grammar: Functional grammar was developed by M. A. K. Halliday. In the 1950s it was called systemic grammar. In functional grammar, meaning is understood as what a speaker wants a listener to understand: the meaning of a sentence is identified with its function. Functional grammar studies the available choices of meaning and relevant words. One important implication of the functional approach to language is its concern with context. Functional grammar takes context into account and thereby brings linguistics towards sociology. It systematically studies relevant features of culture and society that constitute the contexts in which language is used. According to functional grammar, words may be divided into open and closed sets. The open set comprises nouns, verbs,

adjectives and adverbs—lexical or content words. Functional grammar treats groups and phrases as two distinct concepts: a group is an expansion of a word, whereas a phrase is a contraction of a clause. Here 'phrase' refers particularly to the prepositional phrase (PP). Functional grammar also uses structural and functional labels. Structural labels identify the structural nature of elements; functional labels identify their syntactic functions within clauses.

Differences between Modern Linguistics and Traditional Grammar

Linguistics Is Descriptive, Not Prescriptive: Most modern linguistics is descriptive, since it attempts to explain what people actually say, rather than what they ought to say. It describes language in all its aspects without laying down rules of 'correctness'. This contrasts with linguistic study in previous centuries, which was largely prescriptive. Traditional grammar told people how to use language. Teachers should not regard themselves as guardians charged with preserving it. They should prefer to be observers and recorders of facts rather than judges. They hold that everything occurring in natural speech—hesitation, incomplete utterances, misunderstanding and so forth—should form part of their analysis. They recognise that fashion may make one variety of speech appear socially more acceptable than another. But this should not persuade them that a socially approved variety must replace every other variety, or that old words are invariably better than new ones, or the reverse. They regard changes in language and its use as natural and continuous processes rather than things to be feared. Language change should be observed and described. This does not mean that language has no rules: plainly it does, for otherwise we could not understand one another. On the other hand, no individual rule or expression necessarily remains in force for ever.

Linguistics Gives Priority to Spoken Language, Not Written Language: In the past grammarians placed greater emphasis on the written word, partly because writing is permanent. Before the invention of sound recording, fleeting utterances were difficult to study. Traditional classical education was partly responsible as well. People insisted that language conform to the usage of the 'best writers' of classical times; those writers existed for them only in written form.

Yet, if we consider the history of human speech and the experience of individual speakers, spoken language is the primary linguistic fact, while writing is its more or less imperfect reflection. We learn to understand speech before we learn to read, and to speak before we learn to write. We hear more language than we read, and speak more than we write. Spoken language is generally more flexible than written language. It leads linguistic development, while writing follows at varying intervals.

Spoken language is considered primary for several reasons. Historically, speech precedes writing: it existed long before writing systems appeared. Even today many fully developed languages have no writing system. In individual development, children invariably learn to speak before they learn to write. Blind children face no particular difficulty in learning to speak, whereas deaf children encounter considerable difficulties. This indicates that the visual channel is not as important to language acquisition as the auditory channel.

This does not deny the importance of writing, which has advantages unavailable to speech. First, writing allows a message to travel across space. The human voice is effective only within earshot, whereas a written message may be sent and received across vast distances. Second, writing allows a message to travel through time. Spoken words 'die', but a written message may survive far beyond its moment of production, passing from generation to generation and from one culture to another. Third, spoken messages are liable to distortion, whether unintentionally through misunderstanding or otherwise. A written message, by contrast, remains the same whether read a thousand years later or ten thousand miles away.

Spoken utterances share many characteristics with written sentences, but they also exhibit substantial differences. Linguists therefore believe that spoken and written forms belong to different systems, although the systems may overlap. They should be analysed separately: speech first, writing afterwards.

Linguistics Differs from Traditional Grammar in Not Forcing Languages into a Latin-Based Framework: Many traditional textbooks of the past unquestionably assumed that Latin provided a universal framework into which every language would fit. Countless schoolchildren were confused by pointless efforts to force English into an alien pattern. For example, the phrase 'for John' is sometimes described as being in the 'dative case'. This is plainly incorrect, since English does not possess a Latin-type case system. Elsewhere the influence of the Latin model is subtler and therefore more misleading. Many people wrongly regard certain Latin categories as 'natural'. Thus it is commonly assumed that Latin's distinction between past, present and future tenses is indispensable. Yet languages are often encountered which do not have three neatly differentiated tenses. In some languages it is more important to indicate the duration or character of an action—whether it is a single event or a continuing one—than to locate the action in time.

Moreover, judgments about certain constructions often originate in Latin. People frequently argue, for instance, that 'good English' avoids the split infinitive [a split infinitive places an adverb or adverbial phrase between 'to' and the infinitive], as in 'to humbly apologize', where 'humbly' is said

to split 'to apologize'. The claim that a split infinitive is wrong rests on Latin. Purists insist that because a Latin infinitive is a single word, its English counterpart should be kept as close to a single word as possible. For a linguist, judging one language by the standards of another is inconceivable. Linguists reject the assumption that one language can supply an adequate framework for all others. They are seeking a universal framework, but one based on features shared by most of the languages used by humanity.

— Jian Li and Qingming Li

Standard Pronunciation and Writing Conventions for Nepal's Maithili-Language Textbooks, Based on the Maithili Grammar of Ramavatar Yadav

Pronunciation and Writing in Maithili

1. The Fifth Consonants and Anusvāra: The fifth consonants of the five classes are ङ, ञ, ण, न and म. Under the Sanskrit rule, a consonant class is preceded by its own fifth, or nasal, member. For example:

अङ्क (the letter ङ् is used because the following consonant belongs to the क class).

पञ्च (the letter ञ् is used because the following consonant belongs to the च class).

खण्ड (the letter ण् is used because the following consonant belongs to the ट class).

सन्धि (the letter न् is used because the following consonant belongs to the त class).

खम्भ (the letter म् is used because the following consonant belongs to the प class).

The practice described above is less common in Maithili. In most positions an anusvāra is used instead of the fifth consonant: अंक, पंच, खंड, संधि, खंभ and so forth. The grammarian Pandit Govind Jha holds that anusvāra should be written before consonants of the क, च and ट classes, but the fifth consonant itself should be written before the त and प classes: अंक, चंचल, अंडा, अन्त and कम्पन. Modern writers influenced by Hindi do not, however, follow this rule. They write अंत and कंपन even where अन्त and कम्पन would be expected.

The newer method is certainly convenient in some respects, because it saves time and space. Yet in handwriting or print the tiny dot of the anusvāra is sometimes indistinct, and this can seriously change the meaning. The use of anusvāra also carries a comparable risk of mispronunciation. It is therefore appropriate to use the fifth consonants for the classes from क to प. The use of anusvāra with letters from य to ज्ञ, on the other hand, appears uncontroversial.

2. ढ and ढ़: The pronunciation of ढ़ resembles 'र् ह'. Accordingly, ढ़ should be written only where that sound is pronounced; elsewhere ढ should be used. For example:

ढ = ढाकी, ढेकी, ढीठ, ढेउआ, ढङ्ग, ढेरी, ढाकनि, ढाठ, and so forth.

ढ़ = पढ़ाइ, बढ़ब, गढ़ब, मढ़ब, बुढ़बा, साँढ़, गाढ़, रीढ़, चाँढ़, सीढ़ी, पीढ़ी, and so forth.

These words show that ढ generally occurs at the beginning of a word, while ढ़ occurs in the middle or at the end. The same rule applies to ड and ड़.

3. व and ब: In Maithili, व is pronounced as ब, but should not therefore be written as ब. For example, the spoken forms बैद्यनाथ, बिद्या, नब, देबता, बिष्णु, बंश and बन्दना should be written respectively as वैद्यनाथ, विद्या, नव, देवता, विष्णु, वंश and वन्दना. Generally the sound of व is represented in pronunciation by ओ, as in ओकील and ओजह.

4. य and ज: In some places य is pronounced like ज, but it should not be written as ज. Words pronounced यज्ञ, जदि, जमुना, जुग, जाबत, जोगी, जदु and जम should be written, respectively, as यज्ञ, यदि, यमुना, युग, याबत, योगी, यदु and यम.

5. ए and य: Both ए and य occur in Maithili spelling.

Older spelling: कएल, जाए, होएत, माए, भाए, गाए, etc.

Newer spelling: कयल, जाय, होयत, माय, भाय, गाय, etc.

At the beginning of a word, ए is generally used: एहि, एना, एकर, एहन, etc. The forms यहि, यना, यकर and यहन should not be substituted for them. Nevertheless, among certain Maithili-speaking communities, including Tharus, an initial ए is pronounced as य.

In using ए and य, this book follows the older convention, which is considered more appropriate. Neither choice offers any particular

advantage in ease of writing or presents any special difficulty. Moreover, ordinary Maithili pronunciation is closer to ए than to य. In particular, the occasional spelling of कएल and हएब as कैल and हैब further supports the suitability of ए.

6. हि, हु, and the E- and O-Vowel Signs: In the older Maithili writing tradition, हि and हु are attached to words to add emphasis: हुनकहि, अपनहु, ओकरहु, तत्कालहि, चोट्टहि, आनहु, etc. In modern writing, however, the ए vowel sign is often substituted for हि and the ओ vowel sign for हु: हुनके, अपनो, तत्काले, चोट्टे, आनो, etc.

7. ष and ख: In Maithili, ष is most often pronounced as ख: षडचन्त्र (खड़यन्त्र), षोडशी (खोड़शी), षट्कोण (खटकोण), वृषेश (वृखेश), सन्तोष (सन्तोख), and so on.

8. Elision of Sounds: Sounds disappear from words in the following circumstances:

(a) In the verbal suffix अय, य or ए is elided, and the preceding अ is lengthened in pronunciation. An apostrophe or the elision sign (ऽ) is then placed after it. For example:

Full forms: पढ़ए (पढ़य) गेलाह, कए (कय) लेल, उठए (उठय) पड़तौक.

Contracted forms: पढ़' गेलाह, क' लेल, उठ' पड़तौक.

Also: पढ़ऽ गेलाह, कऽ लेल, उठऽ पड़तौक.

(b) In the anterior participial suffix आय (आए), य (or ए) is elided, but no elision mark is inserted. For example:

Full forms: खाए (य) गेल, पठाय (ए) देब, नहाए (य) अएलाह.

Contracted forms: खा गेल, पठा देब, नहा अएलाह.

(c) The feminine suffix इक loses its sound in verbs, nouns and adjectives alike. For example:

Full form: दोसरि मालिनि चलि गेलि.

Contracted form: दोसर मालिन चलि गेल.

(d) The final त of a present participle is elided. For example:

Full forms: पढ़ैत अछि, बजैत अछि, गबैत अछि.

Contracted forms: पढ़ै अछि, बजै अछि, गबै अछि.

(e) The endings इक, उक, ऐक and हीक are elided in verb forms. For example:

Full forms: छियौक, छियैक, छहीक, छौक, छैक, अबितैक, होइक.

Contracted forms: छियौ, छियै, छही, छौ, छै, अबितै, होइ.

(f) The verbal suffixes न्ह and हु, and the aspirate ह, are elided. For example:

Full forms: छन्हि, कहलन्हि, कहलहुँ, गेलह, नहि.

Contracted forms: छनि, कहलनि, कहलौं, गेलऽ, नइ, नञि, नै.

9. Transposition of Sounds: Certain vowel sounds shift away from their original positions. This applies particularly to the short vowels इ and उ. When either appears in the middle or at the end of a word that has become assimilated into Maithili, its sound moves one syllable forward: शनि (शइन), पानि (पाइन), दालि (दाइल), माटि (माइट), काछु (काउछ), मासु (माउस), etc. This rule does not apply to tatsama words preserved from Sanskrit: रश्मि cannot be pronounced रइश्म, nor सुधांशु as सुधाउंस.

10. Use of Halant (्): Maithili generally has no need for the halant (्), since the final अ sound of a word is not pronounced. But words taken unchanged from Sanskrit (tatsama words) employ the halant. In this textbook, words have ordinarily been written without the halant in accordance with Maithili rules; it has been retained at a few places where grammatical explanation makes it indispensable. The orthography adopted here combines the simpler and more appropriate elements of both older and newer Maithili practice. It has been arranged to save time and space and to simplify handwriting and technical production. Today, even native Maithili speakers often have to learn about Maithili through another language; this circumstance has led the authors to give attention to convenience and consistency in writing. At the same time, the authors are conscious that the essential characteristics of Maithili must not be suppressed. The distinguished linguist Dr Ramavatar Yadav says that the search for simplicity must never reach the point where a language's distinctive features are overshadowed. We have tried to carry this principle fully into practice.

The spelling conventions of this book differ in some respects from those of the Class 9 textbook. Continued study, investigation and analysis have brought about these corrective differences. In future revisions of other textbooks, too, we shall endeavour to achieve complete consistency in the spelling conventions of Maithili textbooks.

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Language editing: Neeraj Karna and Rupa Jha.

Maithili Writing Conventions Prescribed by the Maithili Academy, Patna

1. Words that have been written with a particular spelling from the ancient period of Maithili literature to the present should generally continue to be written in that spelling. For example:

Acceptable forms

एखन

ठाम

जकर, तकर

तनिकर

अछि

Unacceptable forms

अखन, अखनि, एखेन, अखनी

ठिमा, ठिना, ठमा

जेकर, तेकर

तिनकर. (Also acceptable as an alternative.)

ऐछ, अहि, ए.

2. The following three sets of alternatives may all be adopted: भऽ गेल, भय गेल or भए गेल; जा रहल अछि, जाय रहल अछि or जाए रहल अछि; कर' गेलाह, करय गेलाह or करए गेलाह.

3. In place of the older Maithili sound न्ह, न may also be written, as in कहलनि or कहलन्हि.

4. ऐ and औ should be written where the intended pronunciation is clearly similar to अइ and अउ: देखैत, छलैक, बौआ, छौक, etc.

5. The following Maithili words are to be used in these forms: जैह, सैह, इएह, ओऐह, लैह and दैह.

6. Omission of a short final इ is generally unacceptable. Thus the acceptable forms are देखि आबह and मालिनि गेलि (for a human subject).

7. Independent short ए or य should be retained in quotations from older Maithili; in modern usage either ए or य may be used: कयल or कएल, अयलाह or अएलाह, जाय or जाए, etc.

8. The य sound that arises naturally between two vowels in pronunciation may optionally be represented in writing: धीआ, अढ़ैआ, बिआह, or धीया, अढ़ैया, बियाह.

9. Where possible, a nasalised independent vowel should be represented by ञ or by the nasalised vowel itself: मैञा, कनिञा, किरतनिञा, or मैआँ, कनिआँ, किरतनिआँ.

10. The following case-ending forms are acceptable: हाथकेँ, हाथसँ, हाथेँ, हाथक, हाथमे. An anusvāra in मे must be avoided altogether. केर may be retained as an alternative to क.

11. After an anterior verb form, कय or कए may be added as alternative indeclinables: देखि कय or देखि कए.

12. Instead of माँग, भाँग and similar forms, write माङ, भाङ, etc.

13. Half-forms of न and म should not be replaced by anusvāra. For the convenience of printing, however, the half-forms ङ, ञ and ण may also be replaced by anusvāra: अङ्क or अंक, अञ्चल or अंचल, कण्ठ or कंठ.

14. The halant should normally be retained, but the inherent अ should be used when a case ending is attached: श्रीमान्, but श्रीमानक.

15. Every simple case marker should be joined to its word, not separated from it. With compound case expressions, separate writing is permissible, as in घर परक.

16. Nasalisation should be expressed by candrabindu. For printing convenience, however, anusvāra may replace candrabindu on complicated vowel signs: हिं in place of हिँ.

17. A full stop should be marked by the vertical stroke (।).

18. Compound words should be written together or connected by a hyphen, not written separately.

19. The elision mark (ऽ) should not be used in लिअ and दिअ.

20. Numerals should be written in Devanagari form.

21. New signs should be devised for certain sounds. Until these are available, the sounds may continue to be represented by अय/आय/अए/आए/आओ/अओ, as before, or by ऐ or औ.

Signed: Govind Jha, 11 August 1976; Shrikant Thakur, 11 August 1976; Surendra Jha 'Suman', 11 August 1976.

Jian Li and Qingming Li write:

Most modern linguistics is descriptive, since it seeks to describe what people actually say, not what they ought to say. It describes language in all its aspects without imposing rules of 'correctness'. This contrasts with the linguistic study of previous centuries, which was largely prescriptive. Traditional grammar told people how to use language.

But by dividing forms into 'acceptable' and 'unacceptable', Govind Jha, Shrikant Thakur and Surendra Jha 'Suman' pronounce judgments of correctness and incorrectness. Ramavatar Yadav, too, appears in places in A Reference Grammar of Maithili to make judgments on the basis of standard usage and related criteria.

A Reference Grammar of Maithili

On page 12 of this book, Ramavatar Yadav observes that the nasal pronunciation of certain words is a characteristic of so-called Standard Maithili, also called the Brahmin dialect of Maithili. On page 376, he records having previously seen some uneducated or semi-educated young Brahmins address older members of 'lower' castes as 'तौ'; by 1996, however, this was no longer tolerated.

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes: Maithili grammarians constructed grammatical frameworks modelled on Sanskrit and Hindi. They did not

consider the distinctive characteristics and differences of Dalit Maithili worthy of examination. Dr Ramavatar Yadav is the only linguist who has given the matter some attention. ... On one occasion, a programme took place at the Anugrah Narayan Sinha Institute of Social Studies in Patna, organised by the Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore. The programme's central concern was the development of Maithili. Several speakers presented their views on how this development should proceed. Dr Meghan Prasad also spoke. His speech did not employ as many honorific forms as the assembled scholars expected. The result was that, in the middle of his address, he was subjected to extremely rude laughter on account of his supposed linguistic lapse. The spectacle disturbed me, and I immediately protested against this kind of linguistic intolerance. [Pachpaniya Maithili, by Subhash Chandra Yadav; collected in Gulo: Kala aa Bhasha, 2022.]

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes, 'Dr Ramavatar Yadav is the only linguist who has given the matter some attention.' This is true, because he has indeed given it some attention. But that attention is not sufficient.

In A Reference Grammar of Maithili, Chapter 1 surveys a hundred years of Maithili grammar; Chapter 2 discusses the sound system and script; Chapter 3 nouns; Chapter 4 pronouns; Chapter 5 adjectives; Chapter 6 verbs; Chapter 7 adverbs; Chapter 8 main and subordinate clause types; and Chapter 9 the syntax and semantics of simple and complex sentences.

Fries writes that prescriptive and scholarly grammars belong to the 'pre-scientific era'. By applying two methods of structural linguistics—distributional analysis and substitution—the traditional eight parts of speech can be dispensed with. [Ch. Fries, The Structure of English, London, 1959.]

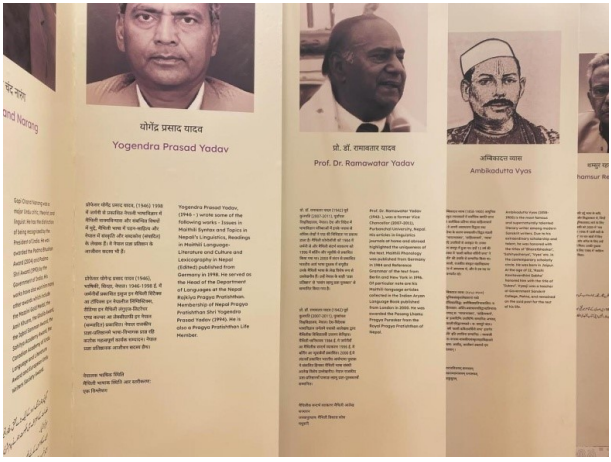
N. M. Rayevska writes: C. Fries divides words into four 'form classes', indicated by numbers, and fifteen groups of 'function words', indicated by letters. The four major parts of an utterance—noun, verb, adjective and adverb—established through substitution procedures in the material recorded by Fries, are given no names other than numbers: Class 1, Class 2, Class 3 and Class 4. The four classes correspond approximately to what most grammarians call nouns and pronouns, verbs, adjectives and adverbs, although C. Fries explicitly cautions readers against attempting to translate his statements into the old grammatical terms they find in textbooks. The groups of function words comprise not only prepositions and conjunctions, but also certain particular words which more traditional grammarians would classify as specific kinds of pronouns, adverbs and verbs.

[N. M. Rayevska, Modern English Grammar, http://web.krao.kg/2_inostran/english/3.pdf]

A Maithili grammar should examine both what people actually say (descriptive rules) and what they are told they ought to say (prescriptive rules). Modern Maithili grammar should include both. The study of formal and informal language (as found, respectively, in such contexts as novels and research essays), regional and socio-economic distinctions, and the status of prescriptive rules belongs to sociolinguistics.

Ramavatar Yadav has presented a structural account of spoken Maithili in his grammar.

At the 2024 New Delhi World Book Fair, life-size posters of Ramavatar Yadav and Yogendra Prasad Yadav in the Language Pavilion.



Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi is divided into four books: (1) Perception (direct apprehension), (2) Inference, (3) Comparison (the recognition of resemblance), and (4) Verbal Testimony (oral testimony). These four books examine the four means of obtaining valid knowledge.

Book One

Perception

Gaṅgeśa's Invocation: This book opens with an invocation to the three-formed Śiva. It therefore begins with a discussion of invocation itself. It is believed that invoking God at the start of an undertaking ensures its completion.

Objection: That an invocation causes the completion of an undertaking cannot be established through positive or negative concomitance, since undertakings have also been completed without any invocation.

Reply to the objection: This is because the invocation was, or may have been, performed in an earlier birth.

Objection: No, this is circular reasoning. Moreover, the empirically observable causes by which an undertaking is completed establish that an invocation is unnecessary.

Reply to the objection: The proof that invocation causes the completion of an undertaking involves an inference in two stages. First, invocation is not condemned by cultivated people; on the contrary, they too begin their undertakings with an invocation. It may then be inferred that the completion of the undertaking is its result, because that result is regularly desired and no other result is available.

Objection: This argument will not hold, because it is already known that an undertaking may be completed in the absence of invocation. No reasoning can establish the alleged causal connection.

Reply to the objection: To support the argument that invocation brings an undertaking to completion, we appeal to a Vedic injunction. Yet no such Vedic statement can be found. We may therefore infer that such invocations were instituted, and continue to be performed, by cultivated people.

Prayer may be performed through the body (as in a gesture of reverence), through speech (singing), and through the mind (meditation). Yet someone without belief in God may also accomplish a task: must such a person have offered an invocation or prayer in a previous birth? And when

an undertaking remains unfinished despite an invocation, are we to say that the ordinary invocation failed to remove numerous obstacles?

It was with reasoning of this kind that this work began, seven or eight hundred years ago!

(References: Karl H. Potter, Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies, 1993; Satish Chandra Vidyabhusana, A History of Indian Logic, 1921.)

Stephen H. Phillips writes:

Genealogical records maintained in Mithila, known as pañjī registers, indicate that he had a wife, three sons and one daughter. One of his sons was Vardhamāna, the celebrated author on Nyāya. Gaṅgeśa evidently attained renown during his lifetime and was called 'Jagad-guru', a designation approximately equivalent, within the academic institutions of his time, to 'distinguished university professor'.

The genealogical records preserved in Mithila indicate that Gaṅgeśa had a wife, three sons and a daughter. One son was the celebrated Nyāya writer Vardhamāna. Gaṅgeśa had already acquired considerable distinction in his lifetime; he was called 'Jagadguru', an appellation that may be understood, in relation to the educational institutions of that period, as broadly comparable to 'distinguished university professor'.

[Stephen Phillips, 'Gangesa', The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, Summer 2020 Edition, Edward N. Zalta (ed.), https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/sum2020/entries/gangesa/]

Gaṅgeśa was not only a Jagadguru but also a Paramaguru. Apart from him, the title Paramaguru was bestowed only later upon the younger Vācaspati, who succeeded the elder Vācaspati.

The injustice which, in the original author's view, Ramanath Jha and Udayanath Jha 'Ashok' did to Gaṅgeśa occurred in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries; the author believes that its harmful consequences reached even Naiyāyikas such as Stephen Phillips. The text notes that Stephen Phillips was the first scholar to produce a complete English translation of all four books of the Tattvacintāmaṇi [Jewel of Reflection on the Truth about Epistemology: A Complete and Annotated Translation of the Tattva-cinta-mani, Bloomsbury Academic, 2020]. Apart from him, by 2021 V. P. Bhatta had completed translations of three of the four books—Perception, Inference and Verbal Testimony—while Comparison remained [Word: The Sabdakhanda of Tattvacintamani, 2005; Perception: The Pratyaksa Khanda of the Tattvacintamani, 2012; Inference: The Anumana Khanda of the Tattva Chintamani, 2021; Eastern Book Linkers, Delhi].

The 'Honour Killing' of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya: First Ramanath Jha, Then Udayanath Jha 'Ashok'—Why Is a Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature More Urgently Needed Today?

On seeing a monograph on Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya written by Udayanath Jha 'Ashok' and published under the copyright of the Sahitya Akademi, the original author hoped that a writer who had received the Bhasha Samman would do justice to Gaṅgeśa. In his assessment, however, neither truth nor research is adequately represented in the monograph.

The original author read it chapter by chapter, hoping that the writer might courageously present the available evidence concerning Gaṅgeśa's ancestry, family and pañjī records. He alleges, however, that Udayanath Jha 'Ashok', like Ramanath Jha, hesitates over the question of Gaṅgeśa's origins and descendants. According to the original critique, despite material having become available after 2009, the 2016 monograph obscured the issue and ultimately did little more than repeat facts published by Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya in 1958.

The original author alleges that the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi is hypocritically perpetuating the suppression, attributed to Professor Ramanath Jha, of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's social and genealogical identity.

The original author offers Ramanath Jha's conservative attitude to the pañjī registers as an example. According to the source text, he knew that the registers contained evidence of inter-caste marriages, yet the 'Dūṣaṇa Pañjī' was kept concealed; the author states that the material was made public in 2009. The source maintains that the Navya-Nyāya philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya married a woman of the leatherworker community (carmakāriṇī) and was born five years after his father's death. In this connection the author refers to his own Pañjī Prabandha, Volumes I–II (http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm), and Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya's History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila (1958).

In a passage cited from Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya's 1958 work, there is a supposition that Gaṅgeśa's family was socially 'low' and subsequently disappeared. The author considers that supposition entirely false. The writer quoted in the passage says that the information was obtained from Professor R. Jha. [1958, Chapter III, pp. 96–99.]

For immediate reference, the following passage is presented from my Pañjī Prabandha (Parts I and II):

Maharaja Harasiṃhadeva belonged to Mithila's Karnata dynasty. In Jyotirīśvara Thakur's Varṇa-ratnākara, Harasiṃhadeva appears as a hero or a king. He was born in 1294 CE and ascended the throne in 1307. After his defeat by Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq in 1324–25, he fled to Nepal. He was the

official founder of Mithila's system of genealogical registers for Brahmins, Kayasthas and Kshatriyas. Gunakara Jha was initially appointed for Maithil Brahmins, Shankaradatta for Karna Kayasthas, and Vijayadatta for Kshatriyas. At Harasiṃhadeva's initiative—and Harasiṃhadeva was a descendant of Nanyadeva, who had established the Karnata dynasty in Śaka 1009—'nandaida śūnyaṃ śaśi śāka varṣe' (Śaka 1019) ... the scholars of Mithila decided in Śaka 1248, corresponding to 1326 CE, to institute the present form of the pañjī system. Subsequently, in 1760 CE, a few intellectually self-indulgent people obtained an order from the ruler of Mithila, Maharaja Madhav Singh, to have the genealogists compile branch books in their present form. Thereafter, in the registers (sometimes described under Śaka 1600, or 1678 CE, but in fact, according to the text, after Madhav Singh, around 1800 CE), a new Brahmin subcaste called Śrotriya arose in Mithila.

On the basis of what he regards as authentic pañjī records, the original author concludes that the Śrotriya subcaste took shape around 1800 CE. Anshuman Pandey writes in his research that Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi supplied him with digital copies of the genealogical records of Maithil Brahmins. Families of hereditary genealogists preserve these records across generations and often regard them as 'intellectual property', thereby restricting researchers' access. Pandey writes that in 2007 he received a complete digital collection of the registers from Gajendra Thakur. [Anshuman Pandey, Recasting the Brahmin in Medieval Mithila: Origins of Caste Identity among the Maithil Brahmins of North Bihar, PhD dissertation, University of Michigan, 2014.]

The source text further states that these pañjī manuscripts were uploaded in 2009 to Videha Pothi—www.videha.co.in—and Google Books.

The original article states that the so-called Maharajas of Darbhanga were zamindars under Cornwallis's Permanent Settlement; there were many such zamindars in British India, but not in Nepal. The appendix to Pañjī Prabandha, Volumes I–II, contains a copy of an order of genealogically based social elevation, which the author interprets as evidence of status being conferred in place of cash. On this basis he argues that, before 1800 CE, the Śrotriyas did not exist as a separate subcaste in British India, and that no such subcaste exists even today among Maithil Brahmins in the Nepalese part of Mithila. Formerly, 'Śrotriya' denoted a follower of a particular tradition of learning; according to the author it continues to be used in that sense in Nepal.

The original pañjī references are given below:

Dūṣaṇa Pañjī—The Black Record

49.

Pañjī Record: Documentary Genealogical Transcription

Original titles and documentary spellings are retained as bibliographic and archival data.

१८८२	चर्मकारिणी	माण्डर	वभनियाम	छादन
तत्त्वचिंतामणि कारकगंगेश	छादनगंगेशक	नाँई	रत्नाकरक-मातृक (अज्ञात)	गंगेश
	वल्लभा	भवाइ	माहेश्वर	
			जीवे	

21//10. From Chhadan: Jagadguru Gaṅgeśa, the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. [Original entry: '२१//१० छादनसँ तत्व चिन्तामणि कारक जगद्गुरु गंगेश']

From Chhadan: the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. [Original entry: 'छादनसँ तत्व चिन्तामणि कारक']

Gaṅgeśa's beloved wife was a woman of the leatherworker community (carmakāriṇī); five years after his father's death, Gaṅgeśa, the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, was born. The record states that he was the child of Medhā, a woman of that community. [Original entry: 'गंगेशक वल्लभा चर्मकारिणी पितृ परोक्षे पञ्च वर्ष व्यतीते तत्व चिन्तामणि कारक गंगेशोत्पत्ति- चर्मकारिणी मेधाक सन्तानक लागिमे छलन्हि']

From Chhadan: the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, 'mōmō' Gaṅgeśa. [Original entry: 'छादन सँ तत्व चिन्तामणि कारक मॅामॅा गंगेश']

'A record concerning Gaṅgeśa, author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, marked "M. M. Pā.", is available in an ancient pañjī.' [Original entry: 'तत्व चिन्तामणि कारक म. म. पा. गंगेशक विषयक लेख प्राचीन पञ्जीसँ उपलब्ध'.]

'An ancient record, somewhere, states that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death.' [Original: 'पितृ परोक्षे पंच वर्ष व्यतीते गंगेशोत्पत्तिः इति प्राचीन लेखनीयः कुत्रापि'.]

Devanand Pañjī 39-2: from Chhadan, Jagadguru Guru Gaṅgeśa; a son, Jayāditya, from Vabhaniyām, son of Sādhukar's wife. [Original entry: 'देवानन्द पञ्जी ३९-२ छादनसँ जगदगुरू गुंरू गंगेश सुताय वभनियामसँ जयादित्य सुत साधुकर पत्नी'.]

Devanand Pañjī 339-3: Jagadguru Gaṅgeśa; son Supan; a daughter in the Bhandarisam line of Harāditya; a son from Gorā Jajiwāl, Jīve's wife; and a son, Sandagahi Bhaveśvara. Elsewhere, at this point, Supan's brother Hariśarmā is mentioned, sometimes with the village Jajiwāl. [Original entry: 'देवानन्द पञ्जी ३३९-३ जगदगुरू गंगेश सुत सुपन दौ भण्डारिसमसँ हरादित्य दौ. । । पुत्र सुताच गोरा जजिवाल सँ जीवे पत्नी ए सुत सन्दगहि भवेश्वर। अत्रस्थाने सुपनभ्रातृ हरिशर्म्म दारिति क्वचित् जजिवाल ग्राम'.]

Devanand Pañjī 30=5: from Chhadan, the author of a treatise, M. M. Pā. Vardhamāna; a son from Khandwalā, Viśvanātha, son of Śivanātha's wife; Gaṅgeśa—M. M. Vardhamāna / Supan / Hariśarmā. [Original entry: 'देवानन्द पञ्जी ३०=५ छादनसँ उपायकारक म. म. पा. वर्द्धमान सुताच खण्डवलासँ विश्वनाथ सुत शिवनाथ पत्नी गंगेश-म. म. वर्द्धमान/सुपन/हरिशर्म्म'.]

Gaṅgeśa, the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, wrote a work whose extent the original author metaphorically equates with twelve thousand books. Returning to the pañjī references, he states that Gaṅgeśa, the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, was born five years after his father's death and married a woman of the leatherworker community. He therefore asks why Ramanath Jha concealed this from Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya. Gaṅgeśa's son Vardhamāna calls him 'sukavi-kairava-kānana-induḥ'—the moon to the grove of water lilies that are good poets. The original author connects the present unavailability of Gaṅgeśa's poems with a wider history of literary and social suppression. The narrative then turns to Vāsudeva of Bengal and Pakṣadhara Miśra of Mithila. Vāsudeva came to Mithila, passed the śalākā examination and obtained the title 'Sārvabhauma'. He memorised Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi and the verses of Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali because teachers in Mithila would not permit students to write down and copy the texts. Vāsudeva's disciple Raghunātha Śiromaṇi defeated his teacher Pakṣadhara Miśra in a scholastic debate and obtained the right of certification; Vāsudeva and Raghunātha established the Navya-Nyāya tradition at Navadvīpa. The original article considers Pakṣadhara Miśra a contemporary of Vidyāpati—distinguishing this Vidyāpati from the poet of the Padāvalī—and states that he wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa. After Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, fewer students came from Bengal to study in Mithila. According to the pañjī records, Gaṅgeśa received both supreme titles, 'Paramaguru' and 'Jagadguru'; the second person said to have received 'Paramaguru' was Vācaspati Miśra II. The original author interprets the disappearance of Navya-Nyāya from Mithila through a metaphor of nature's revenge for the 'honour killing' of Gaṅgeśa and his family.

[The English translation of Gajendra Thakur's Maithili story 'Śabdaśāstram'—'The Science of Words', based on what he describes as the authentic pañjī records of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya—was published in Indian Literature, Vol. 58, No. 2 (280), March/April 2014, pp. 78–93, Sahitya Akademi.]

27. Maithili Wikipedia, Unicode Tirhuta–Kaithi, and Digital Maithili

Abstract

Maithili Wikipedia; Unicode Tirhuta and Kaithi; Maithili in Google Translate, Twitter, and Amazon Alexa; Anshuman Pandey's contribution to the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts; and the contributions of Rajesh Ranjan, Amir E. Aharoni (Israel), Runa Bhattacharya, and Muzammil to Maithili Wikipedia, documented through Facebook and email correspondence. Anshuman Pandey and the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts; Rajesh Ranjan, Amir (Israel), Runa Bhattacharya, and Muzammil and Maithili Wikipedia. Maithili Wikipedia, Unicode Tirhuta and Kaithi, Maithili in Google Translate, Twitter, and Amazon Alexa: the correspondence in Part One should have made the whole matter clear.

Keywords: Wikipedia · Unicode · Tirhuta · Kaithi · digital · Rajesh · font

Abstract

Maithili Wikipedia; Unicode Tirhuta and Kaithi; Maithili in Google Translate, Twitter, and Amazon Alexa; Anshuman Pandey's contribution to the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts; and the contributions of Rajesh Ranjan, Amir E. Aharoni (Israel), Runa Bhattacharya, and Muzammil to Maithili Wikipedia, documented through Facebook and email correspondence. Anshuman Pandey and the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts; Rajesh Ranjan, Amir (Israel), Runa Bhattacharya, and Muzammil and Maithili Wikipedia. Maithili Wikipedia, Unicode Tirhuta and Kaithi, Maithili in Google Translate, Twitter, and Amazon Alexa: the correspondence in Part One should have made the whole matter clear. The screenshots provided there are described below. Part One, Subsection One: Anshuman Pandey and the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts. We shall begin with Part One, Subsection One.

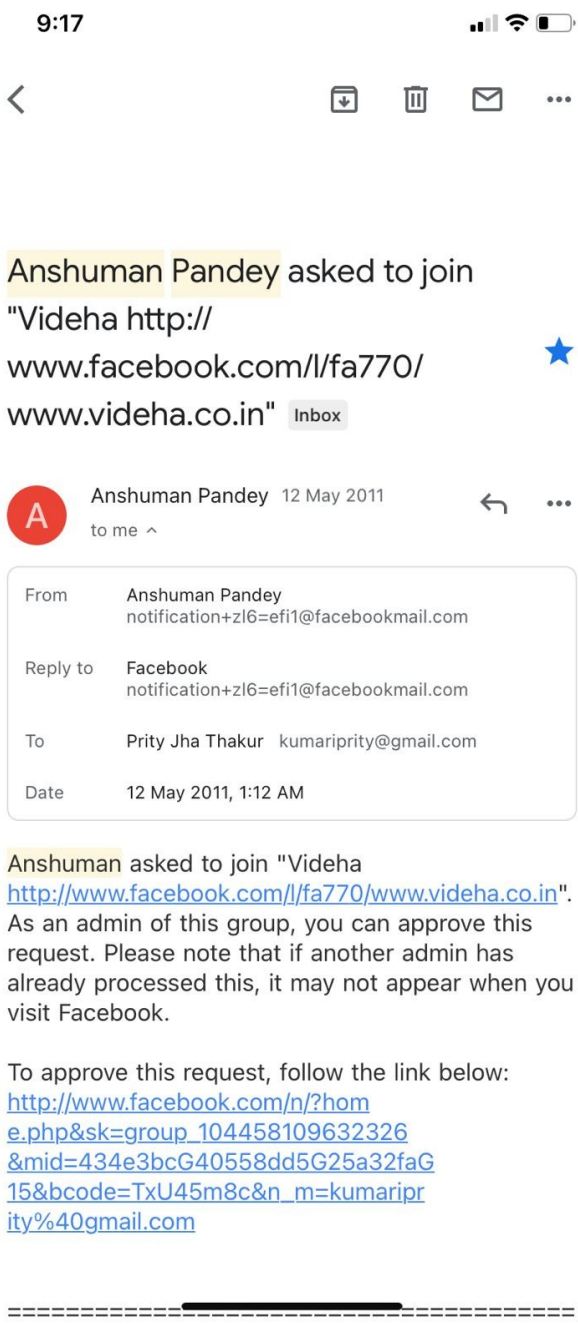
Maithili Wikipedia, Unicode Tirhuta and Kaithi, Maithili in Google Translate, Twitter, and Amazon Alexa

Part One

Anshuman Pandey's contribution to the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts; contributions by Rajesh Ranjan, Amir E. Aharoni (Israel), Runa Bhattacharya, and Muzammil to Maithili Wikipedia (Facebook and email correspondence)

Part One, Subsection One

Anshuman Pandey and the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts



9:17

Anshuman Pandey asked to join "Videha http://www.facebook.com/l/fa770/www.videha.co.in" Inbox

Anshuman Pandey 12 May 2011
to me

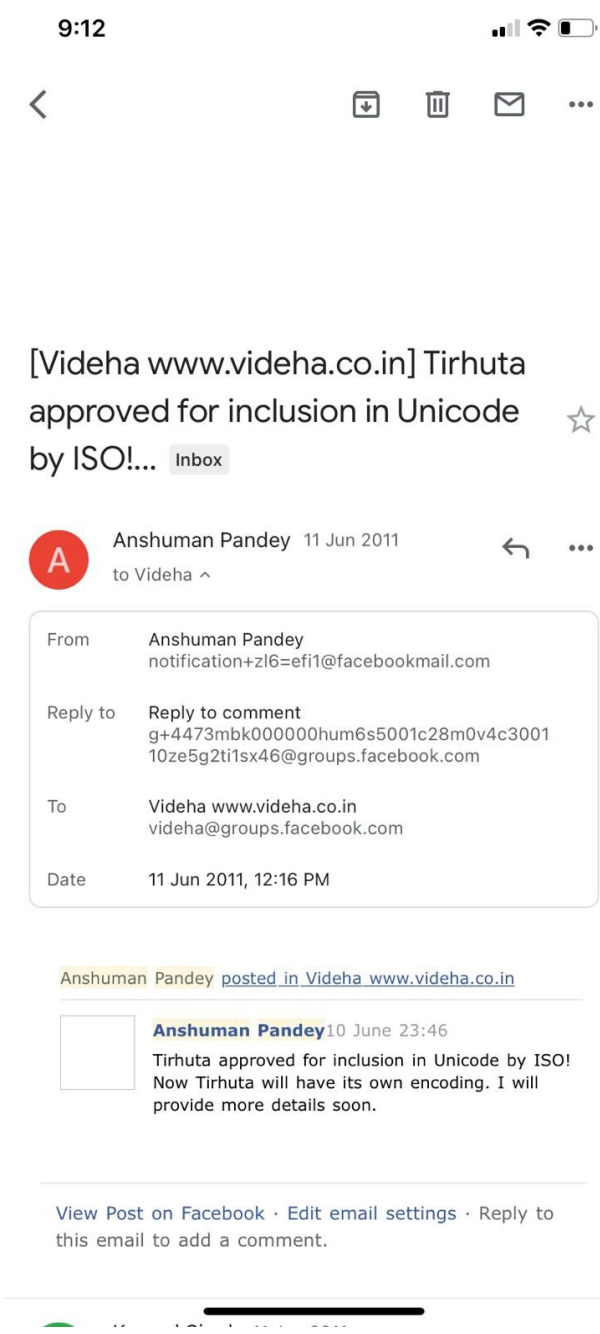
From	Anshuman Pandey notification+zl6=efi1@facebookmail.com
Reply to	Facebook notification+zl6=efi1@facebookmail.com
To	Prity Jha Thakur kumariprity@gmail.com
Date	12 May 2011, 1:12 AM

Anshuman asked to join "Videha http://www.facebook.com/l/fa770/www.videha.co.in". As an admin of this group, you can approve this request. Please note that if another admin has already processed this, it may not appear when you visit Facebook.

To approve this request, follow the link below:
http://www.facebook.com/n/?home.php&sk=group_104458109632326&mid=434e3bcG40558dd5G25a32faG15&bcode=TxU45m8c&n_m=kumariprity%40gmail.com

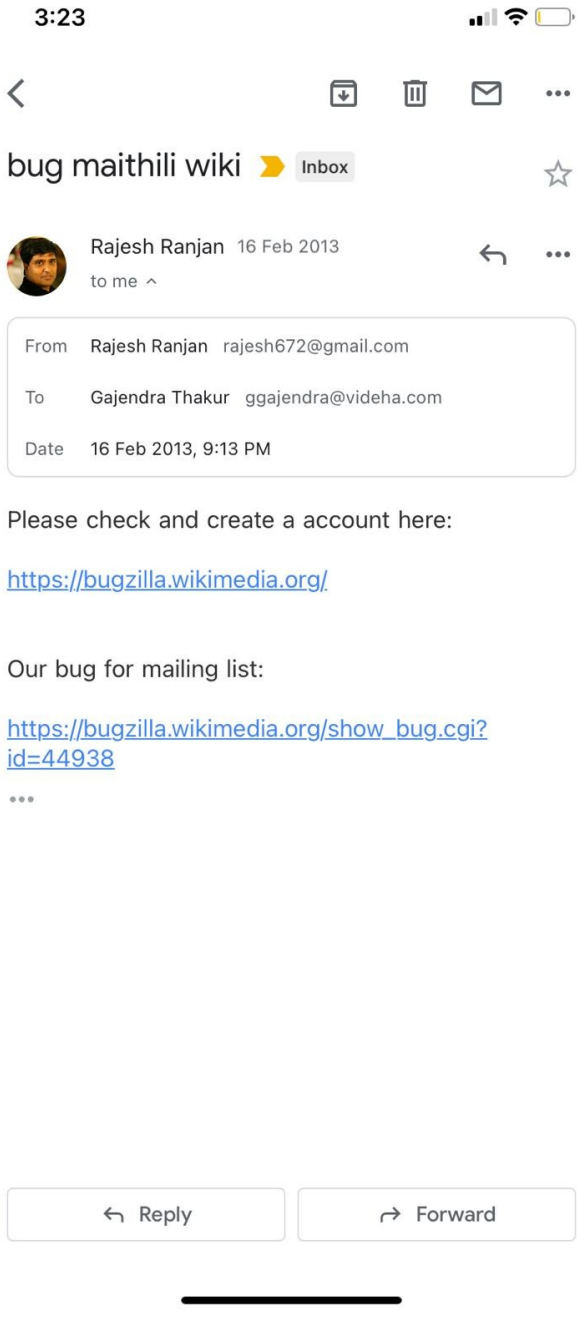
==========

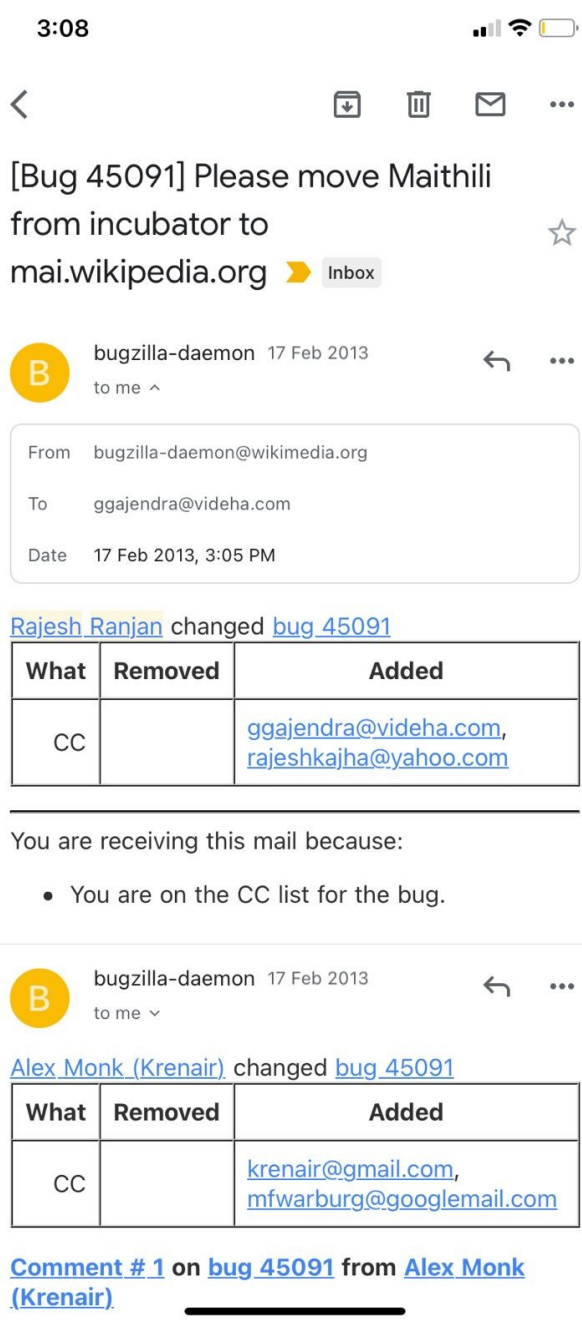
9:13
[Videha www.videha.co.in]
Update: The proposal to encode
Tirhuta in Unicode...
Inbox
Anshuman Pandey 17 May 2011
to me
From
Anshuman Pandey
notification+zl6=efi1@facebookmail.com
Reply to
Reply to comment
g+41tiz5k000000hum6s5001a7p3ikk0900110z
e5g2ti1s93o@groups.facebook.com
To
Prity Jha Thakur kumariprity@gmail.com
Date
17 May 2011, 10:25 PM
Anshuman Pandey posted in Videha www.videha.co.in
Anshuman Pandey 17 May 22:25
Update: The proposal to encode Tirhuta in Unicode was reviewed and accepted by the Unicode Technical Committee. Now the proposal will be reviewed by the ISO technical group JTC2/SC2/WG2. If ISO approves the script, then Tirhuta will be officially placed in the queue for inclusion in a future version of Unicode.
http://std.dkuug.dk/JTC1/SC2/WG2/docs/n4035.pdf
std.dkuug.dk
View Post on Facebook · Edit email settings · Reply to this email to add a comment.



Part One, Subsection Two

Contributions of Rajesh Ranjan, Amir (Israel), Runa Bhattacharya, and Muzammil to Maithili Wikipedia





3:08

[Bug 45091] Please move Maithili from incubator to mai.wikipedia.org Inbox

bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To ggajendra@videha.com
Date 17 Feb 2013, 3:05 PM

Rajesh Ranjan changed bug 45091

What	Removed	Added
CC		ggajendra@videha.com, rajeshkajha@yahoo.com

You are receiving this mail because:

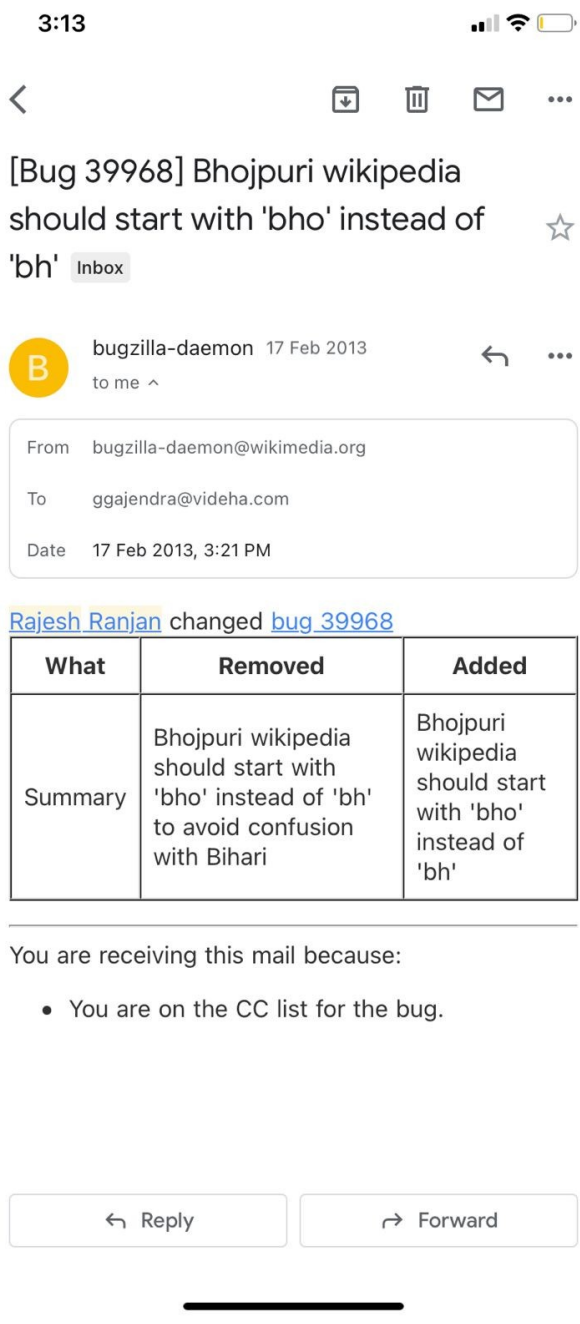
- You are on the CC list for the bug.

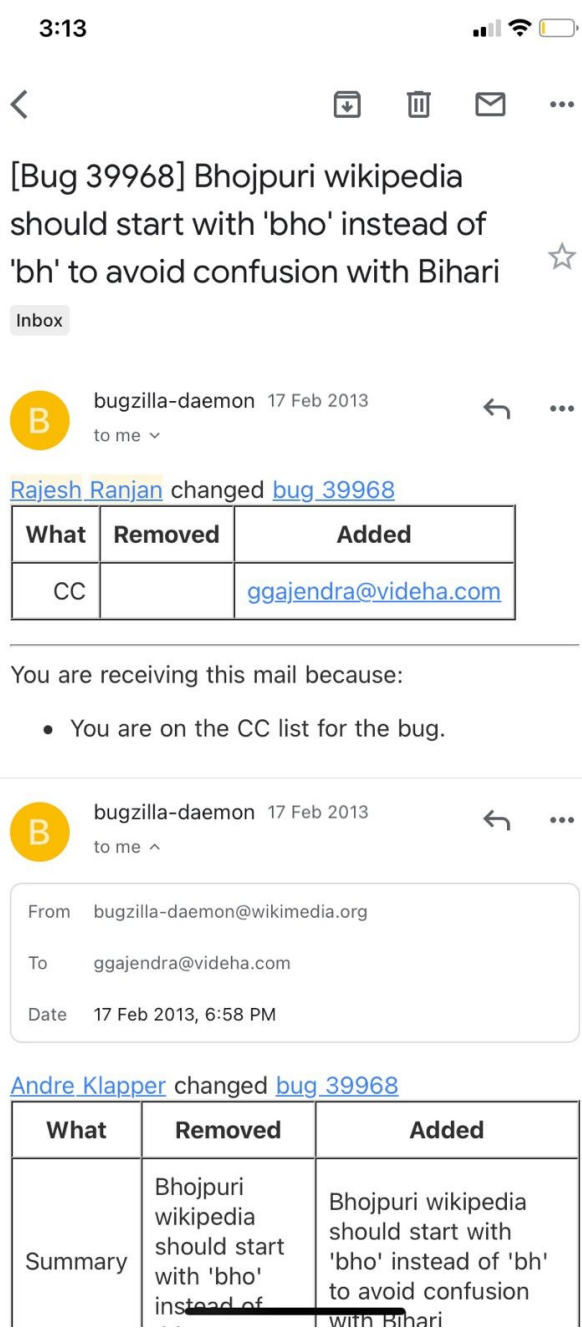
bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me

Alex Monk (Krenair) changed bug 45091

What	Removed	Added
CC		krenair@gmail.com, mfwarburg@googlemail.com

Comment # 1 on bug 45091 from Alex Monk (Krenair)


3:13
[Bug 39968] Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of 'bh'
Inbox
B
bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me
From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To ggajendra@videha.com
Date 17 Feb 2013, 3:21 PM
Rajesh Ranjan changed bug 39968
What
Removed
Added
Summary
Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of 'bh' to avoid confusion with Bihari
Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of 'bh'
You are receiving this mail because:
You are on the CC list for the bug.
Reply
Forward



3:13

[Bug 39968] Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of 'bh' to avoid confusion with Bihari

Inbox

B bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me

Rajesh Ranjan changed bug 39968

What	Removed	Added
CC		ggajendra@videha.com

You are receiving this mail because:

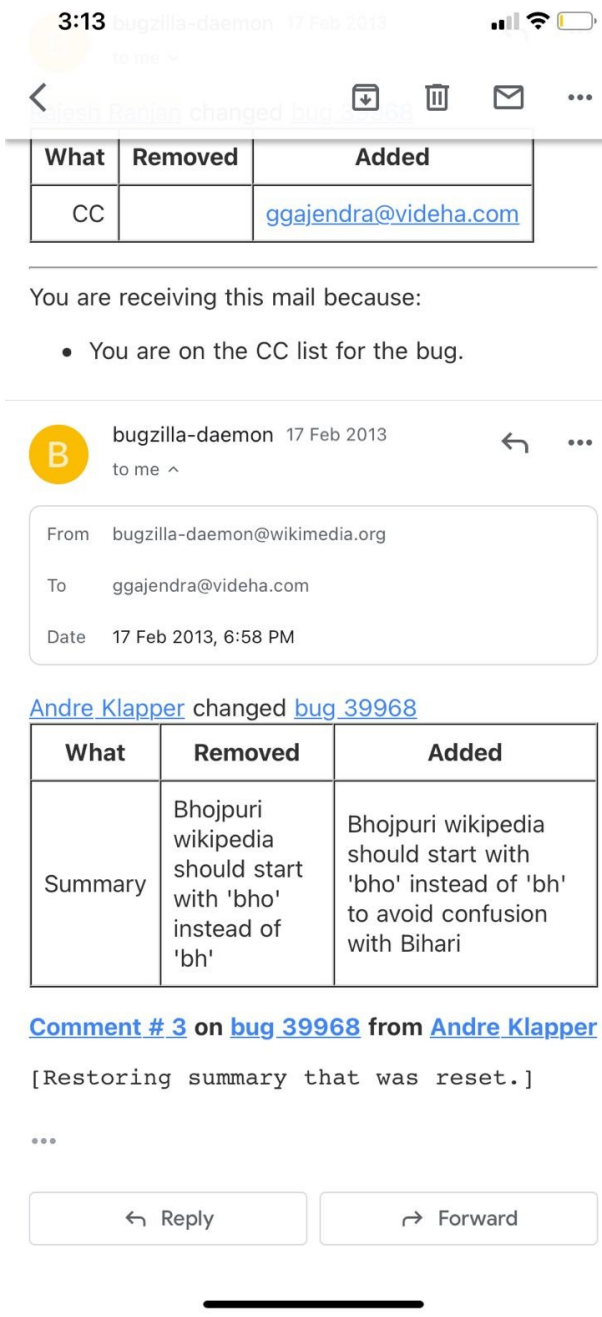
- You are on the CC list for the bug.

B bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To ggajendra@videha.com
Date 17 Feb 2013, 6:58 PM

Andre Klapper changed bug 39968

What	Removed	Added
Summary	Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of [redacted] with Bihari	Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of 'bh' to avoid confusion



3:13

What	Removed	Added
CC		ggajendra@videha.com

You are receiving this mail because:

- You are on the CC list for the bug.

bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To ggajendra@videha.com
Date 17 Feb 2013, 6:58 PM

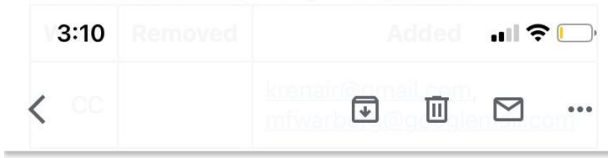
Andre Klapper changed bug 39968

What	Removed	Added
Summary	Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of 'bh'	Bhojpuri wikipedia should start with 'bho' instead of 'bh' to avoid confusion with Bihari

Comment # 3 on bug 39968 from Andre Klapper

[Restoring summary that was reset.]

Reply Forward



Comment # 1 on **bug 45091** from **Alex Monk (Krenair)**

https://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Requests_for_new_languages/Wikipedia_Maithili

•••

B bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me

From	bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To	ggajendra@videha.com
Date	17 Feb 2013, 7:03 PM

MF-Warburg changed bug 45091

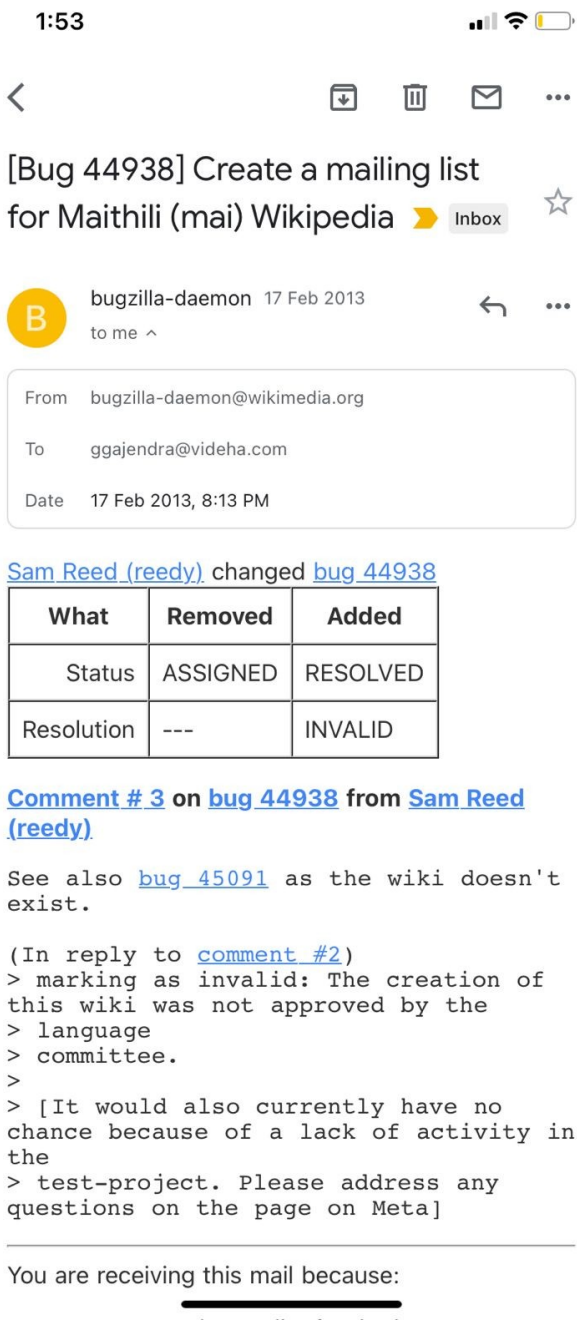
What	Removed	Added
Status	UNCONFIRMED	RESOLVED
Resolution	---	INVALID

Comment # 2 on **bug 45091** from **MF-Warburg**

```
marking as invalid: The creation of
this wiki was not approved by the
language
committee.

[It would also currently have no chance
because of a lack of activity in the
test-project. Please address any
questions on the page on Meta]
```

•••

bugzilla-daemon [redacted]



1:53

[Bug 44938] Create a mailing list for Maithili (mai) Wikipedia Inbox

bugzilla-daemon 17 Feb 2013
to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To ggajendra@videha.com
Date 17 Feb 2013, 8:13 PM

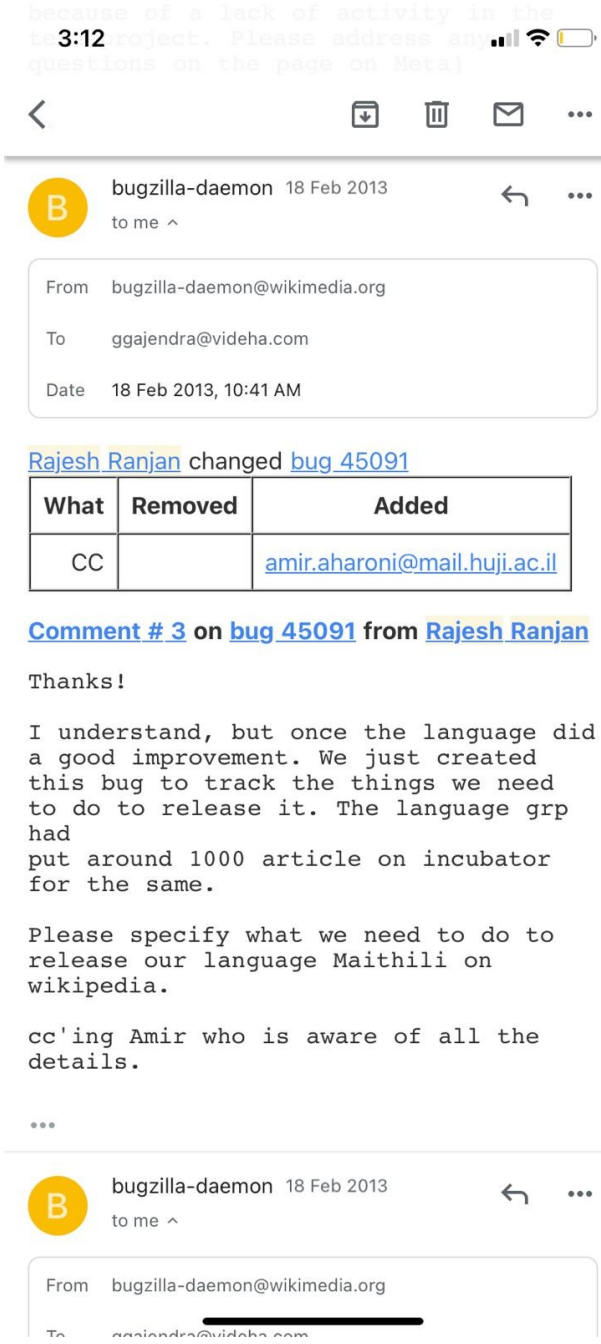
Sam Reed (reedy) changed bug 44938

What	Removed	Added
Status	ASSIGNED	RESOLVED
Resolution	---	INVALID

Comment # 3 on bug 44938 from Sam Reed (reedy)

```
See also bug 45091 as the wiki doesn't
exist.

(In reply to comment #2)
> marking as invalid: The creation of
this wiki was not approved by the
> language
> committee.
>
> [It would also currently have no
chance because of a lack of activity in
the
> test-project. Please address any
questions on the page on Meta]
```

You are receiving this mail because:



3:12

bugzilla-daemon 18 Feb 2013
to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To ggajendra@videha.com
Date 18 Feb 2013, 10:41 AM

Rajesh Ranjan changed bug 45091

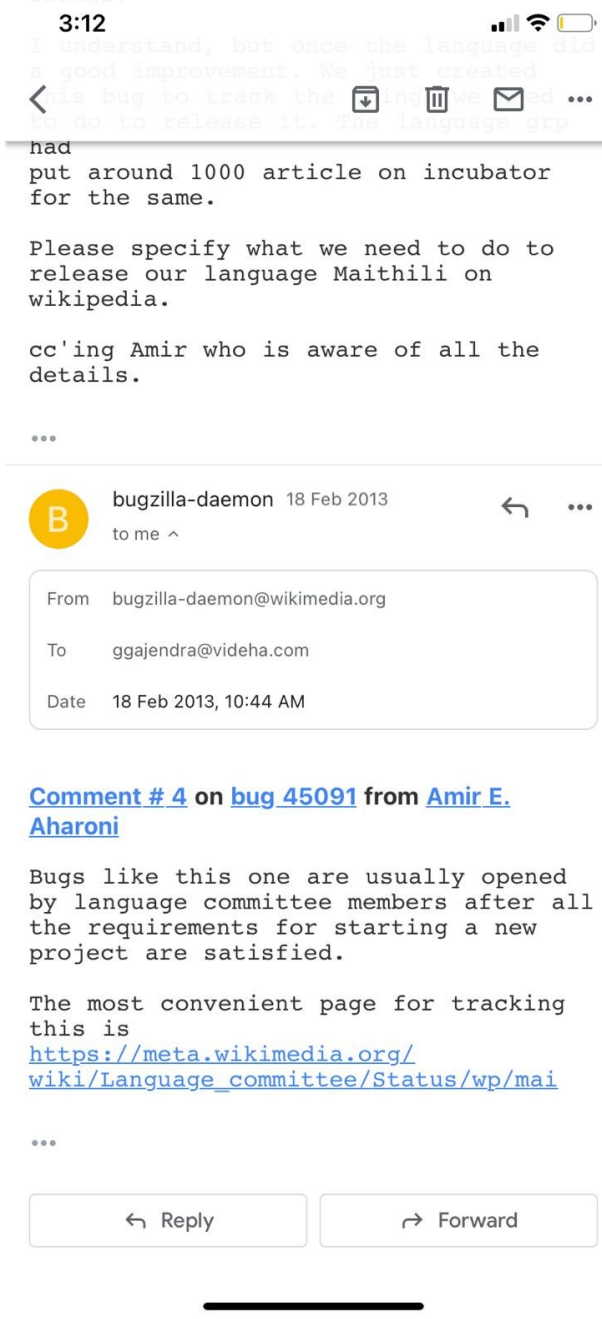
What	Removed	Added
CC		amir.aharoni@mail.huji.ac.il

Comment # 3 on bug 45091 from Rajesh Ranjan

```
Thanks!

I understand, but once the language did
a good improvement. We just created
this bug to track the things we need
to do to release it. The language grp
had
put around 1000 article on incubator
for the same.

Please specify what we need to do to
release our language Maithili on
wikipedia.

cc'ing Amir who is aware of all the
details.
```

bugzilla-daemon 18 Feb 2013
to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org



3:12

had
put around 1000 article on incubator for the same.

Please specify what we need to do to release our language Maithili on wikipedia.

cc'ing Amir who is aware of all the details.

•••

B bugzilla-daemon 18 Feb 2013
to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org
To ggajendra@videha.com
Date 18 Feb 2013, 10:44 AM

Comment # 4 on bug 45091 from Amir E. Aharoni

Bugs like this one are usually opened by language committee members after all the requirements for starting a new project are satisfied.

The most convenient page for tracking this is https://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Language_committee/Status/wp/mai

•••

Reply Forward

You are receiving this mail because:

- You are on the CC list for the bug.

B bugzilla-daemon 18 Feb 2013
to me

Comment # 4 on bug 44938 from Rajesh Ranjan

```
Amir, I put here a request for mailing
list only after the consultation with
you. Please check and let me know what
makes my request invalid.
```

...

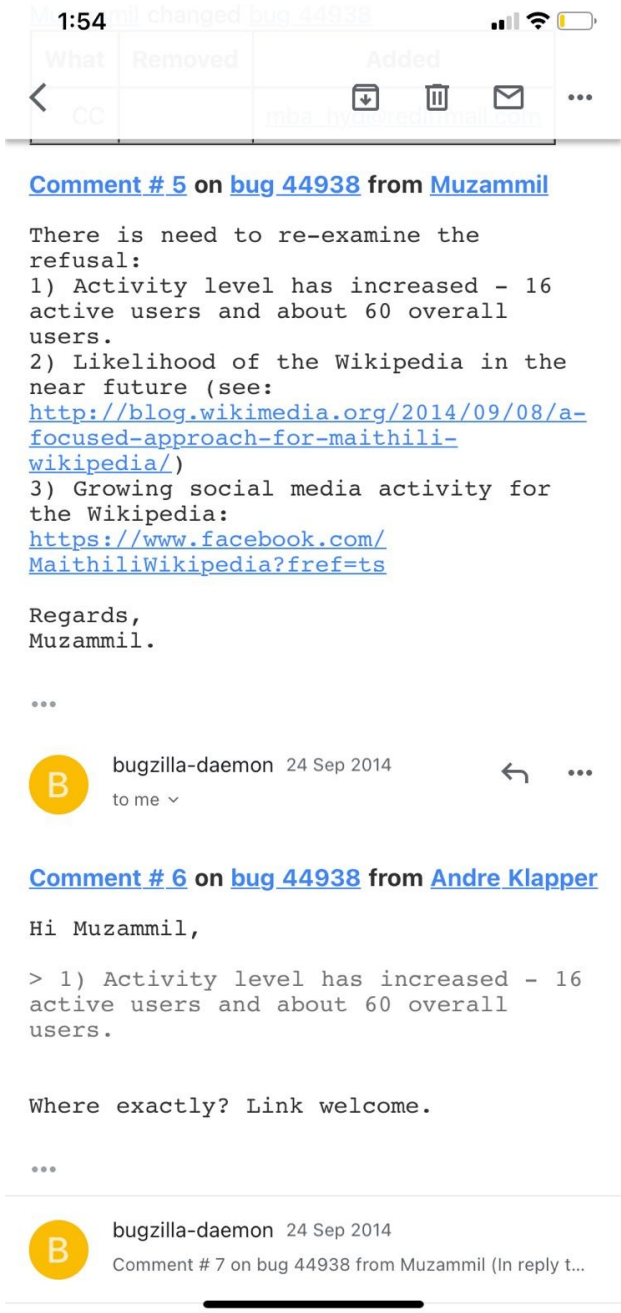
B bugzilla-daemon 24 Sep 2014
to me

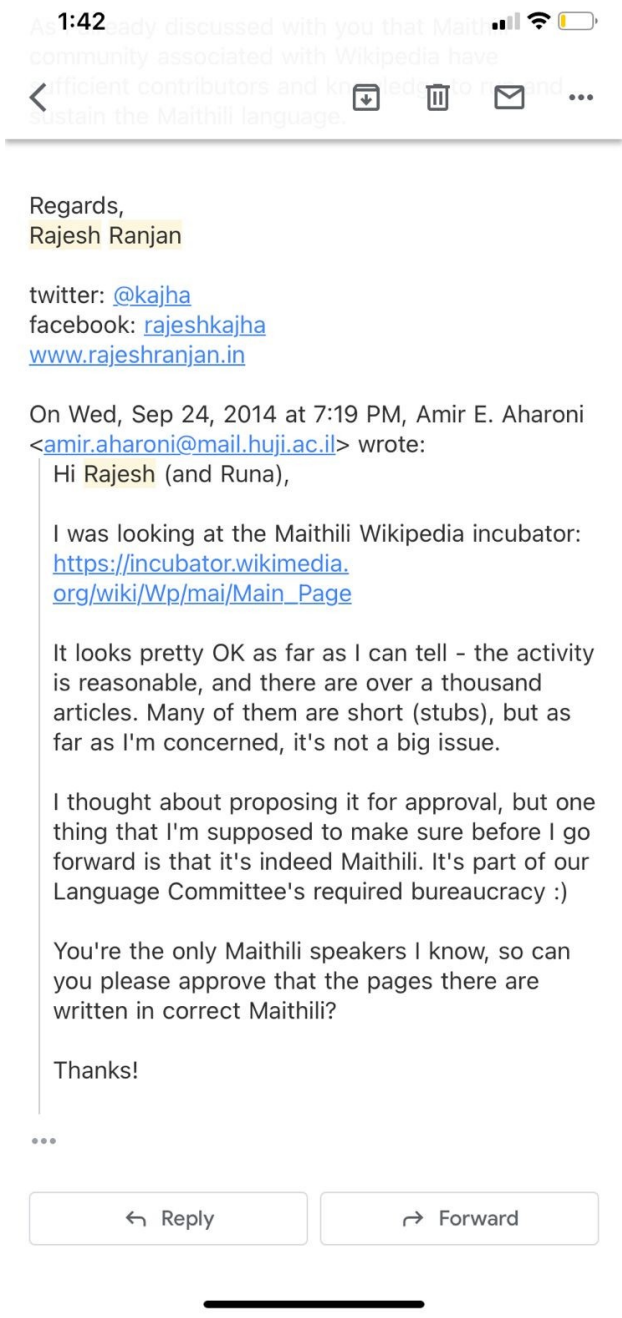
Muzammil changed bug 44938

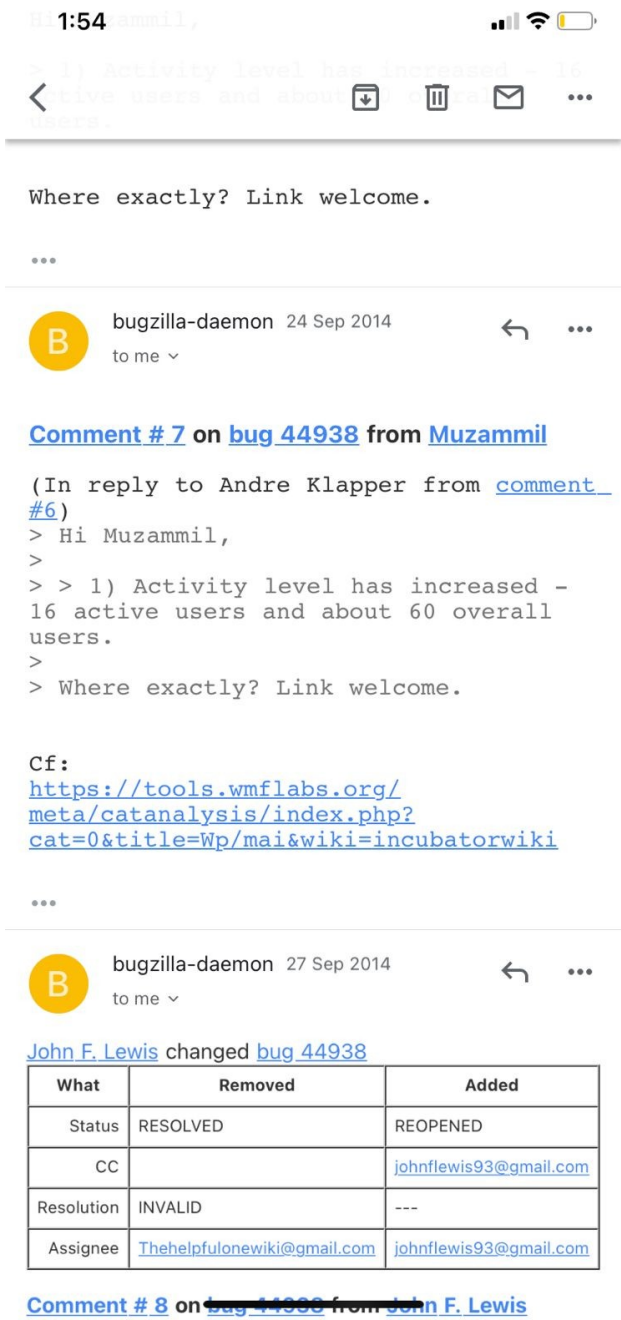
What	Removed	Added
CC		mba_hyd@rediffmail.com

Comment # 5 on bug 44938 from Muzammil

```
There is need to re-examine the
refusal:
1) Activity level has increased - 16
active users and about 60 overall
users.
2) Likelihood of the Wikipedia in the
near future (see:
http://blog.wikimedia.org/2014/09/08/a-
focused-approach-for-maithili-
wikipedia/)
3) Growing social media activity for
the Wikipedia:
https://www.facebook.com/
MaithiliWikipedia?fref=ts
```


1:54
Comment # 5 on bug 44938 from Muzammil
There is need to re-examine the refusal:
1) Activity level has increased - 16 active users and about 60 overall users.
2) Likelihood of the Wikipedia in the near future (see: http://blog.wikimedia.org/2014/09/08/a-focused-approach-for-maithili-wikipedia/)
3) Growing social media activity for the Wikipedia: https://www.facebook.com/MaithiliWikipedia?fref=ts
Regards,
Muzammil.
bugzilla-daemon 24 Sep 2014
to me
Comment # 6 on bug 44938 from Andre Klapper
Hi Muzammil,
> 1) Activity level has increased - 16 active users and about 60 overall users.
Where exactly? Link welcome.
bugzilla-daemon 24 Sep 2014
Comment # 7 on bug 44938 from Muzammil (In reply t...


1:42
Regards,
Rajesh Ranjan
twitter: @kajha
facebook: rajeshkajha
www.rajeshranjan.in
On Wed, Sep 24, 2014 at 7:19 PM, Amir E. Aharoni <amir.aharoni@mail.huji.ac.il> wrote:
Hi Rajesh (and Runa),
I was looking at the Maithili Wikipedia incubator: https://incubator.wikimedia.org/wiki/Wp/mai/Main_Page
It looks pretty OK as far as I can tell - the activity is reasonable, and there are over a thousand articles. Many of them are short (stubs), but as far as I'm concerned, it's not a big issue.
I thought about proposing it for approval, but one thing that I'm supposed to make sure before I go forward is that it's indeed Maithili. It's part of our Language Committee's required bureaucracy :)
You're the only Maithili speakers I know, so can you please approve that the pages there are written in correct Maithili?
Thanks!
Reply
Forward



1:54

Where exactly? Link welcome.

bugzilla-daemon 24 Sep 2014
to me

Comment # 7 on bug 44938 from Muzammil

(In reply to Andre Klapper from comment #6)
> Hi Muzammil,
>
> > 1) Activity level has increased - 16 active users and about 60 overall users.
>
> Where exactly? Link welcome.

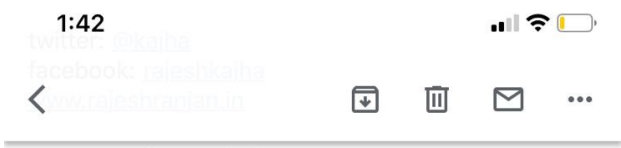
Cf:
https://tools.wmflabs.org/meta/catanalysis/index.php?cat=0&title=Wp/mai&wiki=incubatorwiki

bugzilla-daemon 27 Sep 2014
to me

John F. Lewis changed bug 44938

What	Removed	Added
Status	RESOLVED	REOPENED
CC		johnflewis93@gmail.com
Resolution	INVALID	---
Assignee	Thehelpfulonewiki@gmail.com	johnflewis93@gmail.com

Comment # 8 on [redacted] from John F. Lewis



---------- Forwarded message ----------
From: **Rajesh Ranjan** <rajesh672@gmail.com>
Date: Thu, Sep 25, 2014 at 8:06 AM
Subject: Re: Mathitili Wikipedia
To: "Amir E. Aharoni" <amir.aharoni@mail.huji.ac.il>
Cc: Runa Bhattacharjee
<rbhattacharjee@wikimedia.org>

Hi Amir,

Thanks!

This is Maithili.

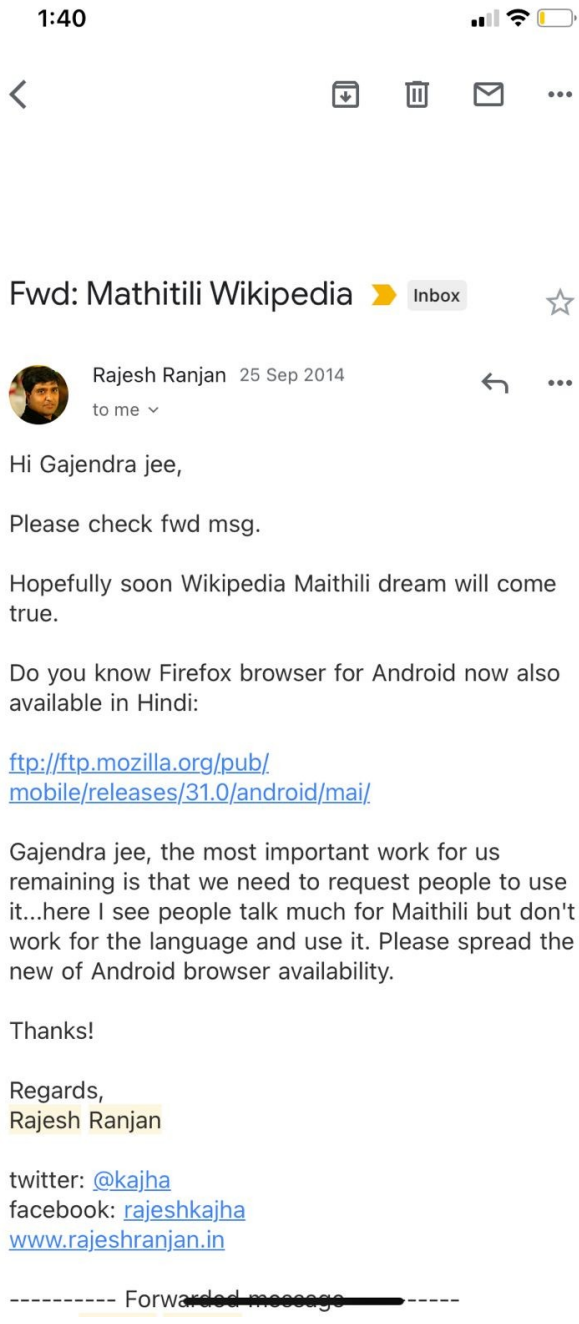
As I already discussed with you that Maithili community associated with Wikipedia have sufficient contributors and knowledge to run and sustain the Maithili language.

Regards,
Rajesh Ranjan

twitter: @kajha
facebook: rajeshkajha
www.rajeshranjan.in

On Wed, Sep 24, 2014 at 7:19 PM, Amir E. Aharoni <amir.aharoni@mail.huji.ac.il> wrote:

> Hi Rajesh (and Runa),
>
> I was looking at the Maithili Wikipedia incubator: https://incubator.wikimedia.org/wiki/Wp/mai/Main_Page
>
> It looks pretty OK as far as I can tell - the activity is reasonable, and there are over a thousand articles. Many of them are short (stubs), but as



1:40

Fwd: Mathitili Wikipedia Inbox

Rajesh Ranjan 25 Sep 2014
to me

Hi Gajendra jee,

Please check fwd msg.

Hopefully soon Wikipedia Maithili dream will come true.

Do you know Firefox browser for Android now also available in Hindi:

ftp://ftp.mozilla.org/pub/mobile/releases/31.0/android/mai/

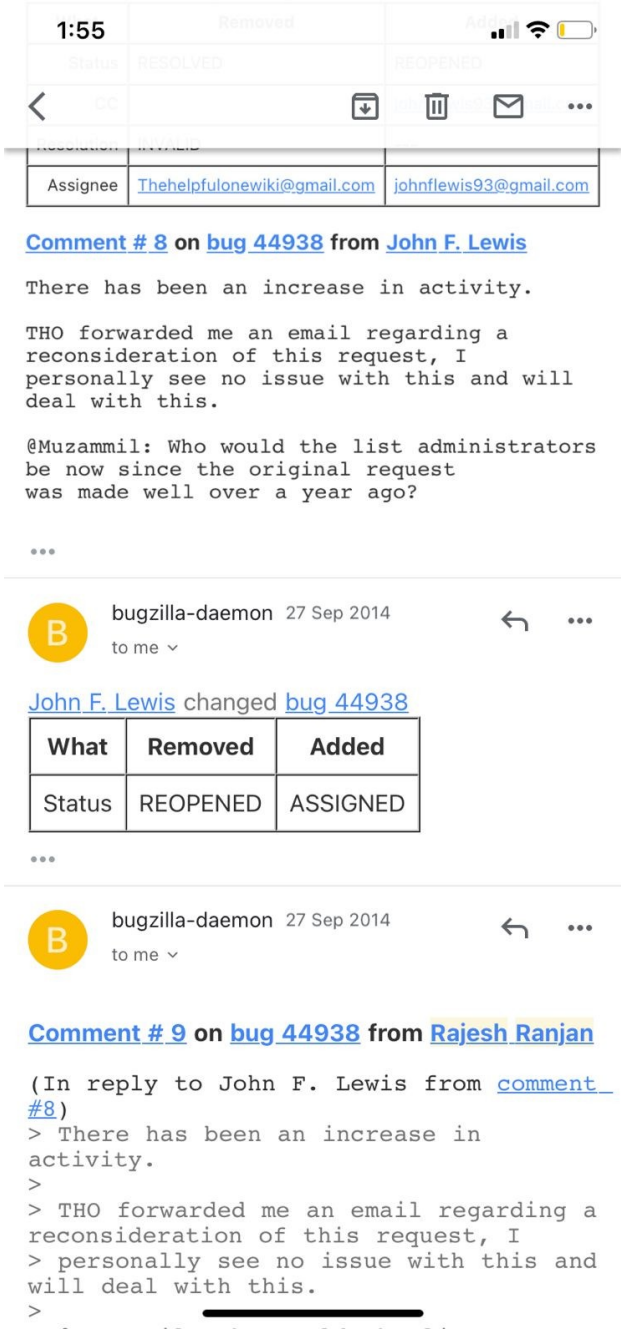
Gajendra jee, the most important work for us remaining is that we need to request people to use it...here I see people talk much for Maithili but don't work for the language and use it. Please spread the new of Android browser availability.

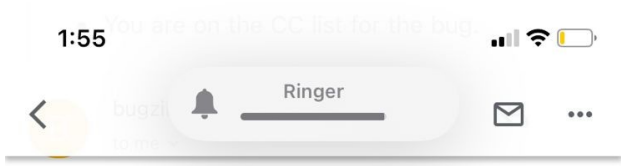
Thanks!

Regards,
Rajesh Ranjan

twitter: @kajha
facebook: rajeshkajha
www.rajeshranjan.in

---------- Forwarded message ----------


1:55
Assignee
Thehelpfulonewiki@gmail.com
johnflewis93@gmail.com
Comment # 8 on bug 44938 from John F. Lewis
There has been an increase in activity.
THO forwarded me an email regarding a reconsideration of this request, I personally see no issue with this and will deal with this.
@Muzammil: Who would the list administrators be now since the original request was made well over a year ago?
bugzilla-daemon 27 Sep 2014
to me
John F. Lewis changed bug 44938
What
Removed
Added
Status
REOPENED
ASSIGNED
bugzilla-daemon 27 Sep 2014
to me
Comment # 9 on bug 44938 from Rajesh Ranjan
(In reply to John F. Lewis from comment #8)
> There has been an increase in activity.
>
> THO forwarded me an email regarding a reconsideration of this request, I
> personally see no issue with this and will deal with this.
>



Comment # 10 on **bug 44938** from **Muzammil**

(In reply to John F. Lewis from comment #8)
> There has been an increase in activity.
>
> THO forwarded me an email regarding a reconsideration of this request, I
> personally see no issue with this and will deal with this.
>
> @Muzammil: Who would the list administrators be now since the original
> request was made well over a year ago?

I think you can add me also an administrator for the list. I will discuss with
Biplab to see if he too is interested as he is very active on the incubator project.

...

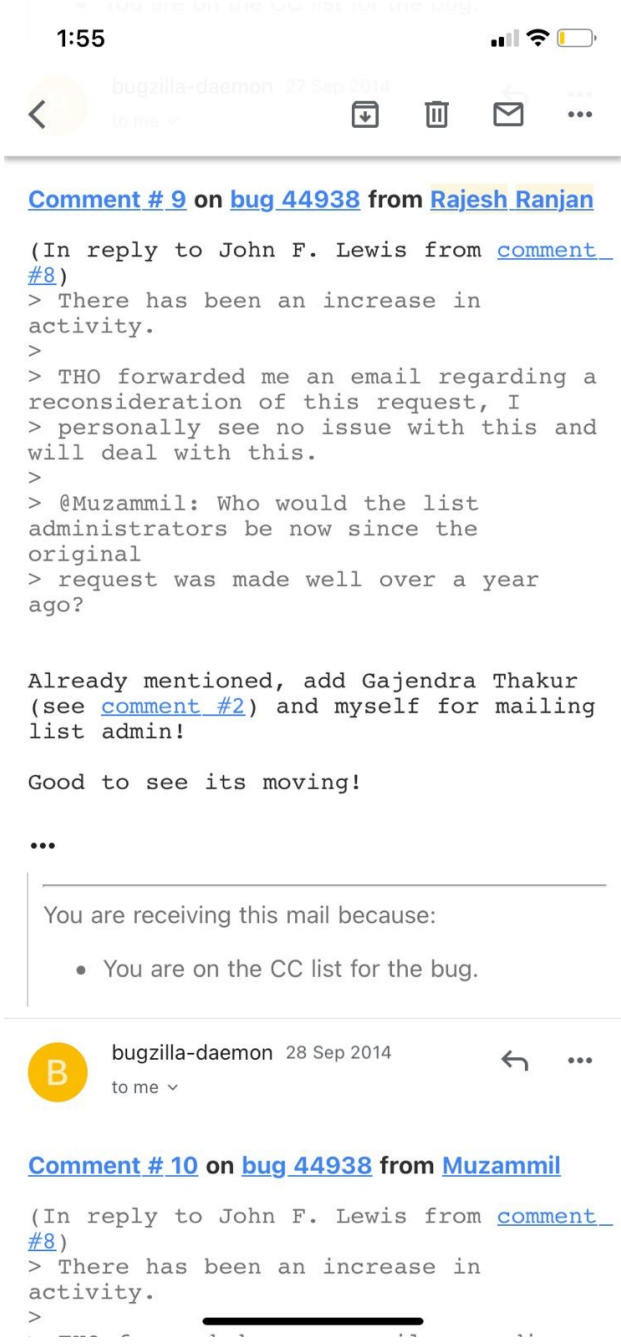
B bugzilla-daemon 28 Sep 2014
to me

बिप्लब आनन्द changed bug 44938

What	Removed	Added
CC		biplabanand@gmail.com

Comment # 11 on **bug 44938** from **बिप्लब आनन्द**

Thanks @Muzammil .....
ok add me too for the admin



1:55

bugzilla-daemon 27 Sep 2014
to me

Comment # 9 on bug 44938 from Rajesh Ranjan

(In reply to John F. Lewis from comment #8)
> There has been an increase in activity.
>
> THO forwarded me an email regarding a reconsideration of this request, I
> personally see no issue with this and will deal with this.
>
> @Muzammil: Who would the list administrators be now since the original
> request was made well over a year ago?

Already mentioned, add Gajendra Thakur (see comment #2) and myself for mailing list admin!

Good to see its moving!

•••

You are receiving this mail because:

- You are on the CC list for the bug.

B bugzilla-daemon 28 Sep 2014
to me

Comment # 10 on bug 44938 from Muzammil

(In reply to John F. Lewis from comment #8)
> There has been an increase in activity.
>

1:56

बिप्लब आनन्द changed bug 44938

What	Removed	Added
CC		biplabanand@gmail.com

Comment # 11 on bug 44938 from बिप्लब आनन्द

```
Thanks @Muzammil .....
ok add me too for the admin

--We are very close,let make it happen-
-- Jai Mithila Jay Maithil------
```

bugzilla-daemon 6 Oct 2014

to me

From bugzilla-daemon@wikimedia.org

To ggajendra@videha.com

Date 6 Oct 2014, 1:25 AM

John F. Lewis changed bug 44938

What	Removed	Added
Status	ASSIGNED	RESOLVED
Resolution	---	FIXED

Comment # 12 on bug 44938 from John F. Lewis

```
Created. Setting list admins and
sending the password to all shortly.
```

Part Two

The correspondence in Part One should already have made everything clear. The screenshots presented there are described as follows.

Part One, Subsection One: Anshuman Pandey and the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi Unicode fonts

Let us first turn to Part One, Subsection One. Its screenshots are described below.

Anshuman Pandey had submitted proposals for Unicode fonts for Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) and Kaithi. He submitted a proposal for the Mithilakshara (Tirhuta) font on 30 September 2009 and a revised proposal on 5 May 2011; both acknowledged the contribution of Videha. On 12 May 2011, Anshuman Pandey joined Videha's Facebook group, https://www.facebook.com/groups/videha. On 17 May he informed the Videha Facebook group that the Unicode Technical Committee had approved the proposal and forwarded it to ISO. On 10 June he also posted there the news of ISO's approval of Tirhuta Unicode; in Indian Standard Time it was already 11 June. These fonts have now been made and are available for download at the links below.

Download Tirhuta and Kaithi fonts — Google's Noto Fonts project / C-DAC

Download the Unicode Tirhuta font

Mithila Uni

Kaithi

Part One, Subsection Two: Contributions of Rajesh Ranjan, Amir E. Aharoni (Israel), Runa Bhattacharya, and Muzammil to Maithili Wikipedia

We now turn to Part One, Subsection Two. Its screenshots are described below.

I have written repeatedly in Videha about Rajesh Ranjan and Sangeeta Kumari, contributors to the Fedora Project and Mozilla. Their names also appear in my English–Maithili Computer Dictionary. At my request, Rajesh Ranjan also spoke with Amir of Israel about Maithili Wikipedia at a Wikipedia summit.

Work had begun on this project even before 2008; a detailed account appears in Part Three. The matter passed through discussions of Bhojpuri and "Bihari" before arriving at Maithili. Work on MediaWiki and its translation programme then began, and more than one thousand articles were submitted. Rajesh Ranjan passed on to me whatever the Wikipedia

Language Committee asked him to undertake. Let me state here that one hundred per cent of those thousand articles in the Maithili Wikipedia Incubator—that is, its draft stage—were contributed by Videha. Some further contributions came later. Even when Maithili Wikipedia went live from the Incubator, ninety-nine per cent of its articles were from Videha, and even now ninety-five per cent of the articles there are, in the author's account, owing to Videha. On 18 February 2013, Amir E. Aharoni (Israel) acknowledged that the project's work was complete, since members of the Language Committee create this kind of bug report only then. I had been added to Bugzilla on 17 February 2013; however, because activity was extremely low, the Language Committee did not give its approval. Rajesh Ranjan protested. Through Videha and social media I too appealed to various ISPs to increase activity, but I regret to report that contributions from non-Videha members remained zero. Nevertheless, the number of active users rose to sixteen and the total number of users to sixty (see the screenshot of 24 September 2014). When we count Maithili speakers in the tens of millions, does this number not disappoint you?

On 24 September 2014, Amir E. Aharoni (Israel) informed Rajesh Ranjan and Runa Bhattacharya that there were more than one thousand articles, that activity was reasonably satisfactory, and that he knew no Maithili speaker apart from Rajesh Ranjan. He therefore asked them to confirm whether all these articles were indeed in Maithili; if so, he would put forward a proposal for approval. On the same date, Rajesh Ranjan told Amir E. Aharoni that all the more than one thousand articles were indeed written in Maithili.

On 25 September 2014, Rajesh Ranjan forwarded all the messages to me and said that the dream of Maithili Wikipedia was now about to be realised. Today it astonishes me to see people who made no contribution jumping about, while Rajesh Ranjan and Runa Bhattacharya remain silent despite having done so much. Maithili is indeed a fortunate language! In the same email, Rajesh Ranjan wrote that the fundamental question was why people deliver grand speeches in the name of Maithili yet neither work for it nor use it. Muzammil, too, became involved from the Wikipedia side. Rajesh Ranjan telephoned to ask me to become an administrator, although he knew that I keep away from the malady of power, and that this avoidance is not confined to the Sahitya Akademi. Instead, I suggested Biplab Anand: he was young and from Nepal and might therefore act impartially, as Wikipedia requires—although where does one find such impartiality in Maithili affairs? On 27 September 2014, Rajesh Ranjan recommended Biplab Anand, and the recommendation was accepted: Biplab Anand became an administrator of Maithili Wikipedia on 28 September 2014. I feel that both his spelling and his commitment need improvement; he is hardworking, however, and I wish him well.

Part Three

1

[Editorial: Videha, Issue 85, 1 July 2011 (Year 4, Month 43, Issue 85)]

Notice: Anshuman Pandey's applications to encode both Kaithi and Mithilakshara in the Universal Character Set (Unicode) were accepted. This allowed work to proceed on the base fonts for both scripts. The base font for Mithilakshara was named "Tirhuta," just as "Mangal" is used for Devanagari and "Vrinda" for Bengali. The third revised application for Mithilakshara describes Videha's contribution in detail: "Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22; Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http://www.videha.co.in/." In his acknowledgements, Anshuman Pandey states that Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi met him, corresponded extensively about Maithili, furnished valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and gave feedback on the requirements for encoding Maithili in the UCS.

Notice 2. Google Maithili: Google Language Tools

http: //www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseProject

Contribute to Google Translate. When revising an edit, explain in English, in the field for the reason, that there is no language named "Bihari." Translate at this link after signing in with a Google account.

http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseActivity...

Keep checking this link for the availability of Maithili: http://www.google.co.in/language_tools? hl=en

Notice 3. Maithili Wikipedia

Members of Videha have translated 2,600 MediaWiki messages from English into Maithili. Now visit http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special: Translate...; in the Group dropdown, select and translate the untranslated messages. If you are not a Wikipedia translator, request permission to translate into Maithili at http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project: Translator. Before doing so, log in at the top right (or create an account if you do not have one), select Maithili as your language in Preferences, click the link to your user account, and create your user page. You should receive permission to translate after a while. Then begin translating.

In Videha's third issue (1 February 2008), I had announced: "Wikipedia had articles about Maithili, but no articles in Maithili, because a Maithili Wikipedia had not yet been approved. I have been working on this for a long time and am pleased to report that on 27 January 2008 approval was granted to begin a wiki for the Maithili language. Full approval of the

project, however, will come only if at least five people from different places work regularly as editors." Now, after more than three years, with all the preliminary requirements for Maithili Wikipedia fulfilled, Wikipedia's Language Committee has understood that Maithili is not a language to be described simply as "Bihari" and requires a Wikipedia of its own. Gerard M. of Wikipedia writes (http://ultimategerardm.blogspot.com/.../bihari-wikipedia...).

"This information about Maithili and its relation to the Bihari group of languages was provided by Umesh Mandal. Umesh is working on the localisation of Maithili on Wikipedia. ... The Language Committee is trying to understand whether Maithili can be placed within the Bihari language group. ... But Umesh's reply has now made it absolutely clear that the answer is 'no'."

In an article entitled "Maithili aur Hindi" in the Hindi monthly Patal, edited by Ramdayal Pandey, Ramvilas Sharma had attempted to present Maithili as a dialect of Hindi. Yatri Ji opposed this in a Hindi article when he was forty-three years old (Aryavarta, 14/21 February 1954); Rajmohan Jha's Maithili translation of that article appeared in the second issue of Arambh. Umesh Mandal's successful intervention is especially significant in another respect: he is only thirty years old. When Maithils working in computer science are to be found from Hyderabad and Bangalore to Seattle, what does it reveal that this objection or correction came not from them but from a young admirer of Maithili living in a remote area of Mithila?

Through fieldwork, Umesh Mandal has also digitised, in audio and video form, songs sung by people of every caste and religion in Mithila; these are available in the Videha archive.

The following five sites belong to the Maithili Wiki project. Help take the project forward.

http: //translatewiki. net/wiki/Project: Translator

http://meta.wikimedia.org/.../Requests.../Wikipedia_Maithili

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special: Translate...

http: //incubator. wikimedia. org/wiki/Wp/mai

http: //translatewiki. net/wiki/MediaWiki: Mainpage/mai

2

Videha seminars: On 6–7 and 13–14 December 2008; on 5–6 and 12–13 December 2009; on 4–5 and 11–12 December 2010; and, in the final discussions, on 17–18 and 24–25 December 2011, discussions and practical

laboratory demonstrations were held at Nirmali, Supaul district, concerning Google Translator Toolkit and Google Language Tools for Maithili, approval of applications to encode both Kaithi and Mithilakshara in the Universal Character Set (Unicode), and Maithili Wikipedia. Many relevant specialists attended. Some articles and creative writings were subsequently received by post and email. A brief account follows.

Google Translator Toolkit now accepts Maithili as both a source and a target language. See
http://support.google.com/translate/toolkit/bin/answer.py...

And: http://translate.google.com/toolkit/list? hl=en...

Following Videha's objections, Google acknowledged, according to the author, that no language called "Bihari" exists. "Maithili Wikipedia" had already been established through Videha, and Wikipedia had earlier accepted the same point regarding the name "Bihari."

Google Maithili: Google Language Tools

Here, under languages in English, select "Bihari" and contribute to Google Translate. When changing your edits, explain in English in the reason field that there is no language named "Bihari." Translate using this link after logging in with your Google account.

[Update: Another success for Videha — the Google search engine is now in Maithili.

Another success for Videha — the Google search engine is now in Maithili. Earlier Google had treated it as the Bihari language; following Videha's objections, however, Google accepted that the Maithili language should have a separate search engine. Wikipedia, the author writes, had already accepted this following Videha's objections. The link is https://www.google.com/webhp? hl=bh. [Google had launched a search engine under the name "Bihari," although there is no distinct language by that name. Someone had translated "Bihari" as Angika, and the search engine consequently appeared under Angika. Then Vinit Utpal of Videha wrote the letter reproduced above. Volunteers from Videha undertook almost the entire translation, and appeals were also made to others, but contributions from outside were zero. The few contributions that did arrive in Roman letters were corrected. Google is now displaying the search engine in Maithili, although much work still remains.]

See the discussion at a Videha seminar on this subject:
http://esamaad.blogspot.in/2012/01/blog-post_08.html

But this is only the beginning.

After the translation is complete, Maithili will appear here:

http://www.google.com/language_tools? hl=bh

http://www.google.com/language_tools

VINIT UTPAL'S LETTER

Google launched a search engine under the name "Bihari," although there is no separate language called Bihari. Someone translated the name "Bihari" as Angika; consequently the search engine appeared as Google Angika. Vinit Utpal of Videha then wrote the letter mentioned above. Nearly all the translation was carried out voluntarily by Videha; appeals were also made to others, but outside contributions remained zero. A few people who did contribute used Roman script, and their contributions were corrected. The search engine is now displayed in Maithili, but much work remains to be done.

Vikas Thakore commented on your photograph.

Vikas wrote: "https://www.google.com/webhp? hl=bh"

Sir, Google Maithili has existed at this link since 2004 ...

So what is the point of this sudden ... celebration (or whatever)?

Gajendra Thakur: Read the article about the Translate option — http://esamaad.blogspot.in/2012/01/blog-post_08.html

Vikas Thakore commented on your photograph.

Vikas wrote: "Yes ... thank you."

"I apologise for troubling you unnecessarily."

After translation is completed, Maithili will appear here: http://www.google.com/language_tools? hl=bh

After translation is completed, Maithili will appear here. Previously "Bihari" appeared here; clicking it brought up Maithili.

http://www.google.com/language_tools

Update: 28 March 2012.]

[Notice: Anshuman Pandey's applications to encode Kaithi and Mithilakshara in the Universal Character Set (Unicode) were accepted. The process of creating base fonts for both scripts consequently moved forward. The base font for Mithilakshara was named "Tirhuta," as "Mangal" is used for Devanagari and "Vrinda" for Bengali. The third revised application for Mithilakshara gave a detailed account of Videha's contribution: "Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22;

Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http://www.videha.co.in/." Anshuman Pandey's acknowledgement states that Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi met him, corresponded extensively with him about Maithili, provided valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books and other records, and gave feedback concerning the need to encode Maithili in the UCS.]

Notice 2. Google Maithili: Google Language Tools

Notice 3. Maithili Wikipedia

http: //translatewiki. net/wiki/Project: Translator

http: //incubator. wikimedia. org/wiki/Wp/mai

TIRHUTA UNICODE

See Anshuman Pandey's final Unicode Mithilakshara application, dated 5 May 2011, at http://std.dkuug.dk/JTC1/SC2/WG2/docs/n4035.pdf. On page 23, the Tirhuta edition of Videha's eightieth issue is included as "Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22)." The references on page 12 include Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal, Issue 80 (15 April 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed.], http://www.videha.co.in/. On the same page appears an acknowledgement of the Videha editor's contribution:

"Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and corresponded at length about Maithili; he supplied valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books and other records, and provided feedback on the need to encode Maithili in the UCS."

Distribution of a leaflet about Unicode at the Sahitya Akademi story symposium (Gajendra Thakur; update of 31 March 2012)

Dr Ramanand Jha Raman distributed a leaflet on Unicode at a Sahitya Akademi story symposium. To me it demonstrated only that its author had no understanding of Unicode and lacked even the elementary knowledge required for the creation of either Western or Unicode fonts. The leaflet nevertheless has value for anyone wishing to learn how a prejudiced, partisan history of Maithili literature is written. Earlier, the Chetana Samiti had discussed its supposed contribution to Unicode in its souvenir! When Anshuman Pandey, who applied for Tirhuta Unicode encoding, travelled to Patna, I had told him that Shiv Kumar Thakur had a bookshop at Vidyapati Bhavan, where he could buy Maithili books. For two or three days, however, both the shop and the committee were closed, so he had to return. Later, someone there told him that he kept coming every day, but that the committee would remain closed for at least another fourteen or fifteen days because two groups had quarrelled. This was his

experience, and yet the committee's souvenir recounts the contribution it allegedly made to Unicode! When he asked for Govind Jha's address, a certain "scholar" (!) dismissed the matter, saying, in effect, "What would he be able to tell you?", and refused to provide the address. It was finally obtained from elsewhere.

3

[https://esamaad.blogspot.com/2012/01/blog-post_08.html?fbclid=IwAR20AS6in4rK00uC1CK1sX2dM7ivqI_CuF8KFNAbIN7NH12-pTuPKlkdMsE] Samadiya, 8 January 2012

Google Translator Toolkit now provides for Maithili as both a source and a target language. See http://support.google.com/translate/toolkit/bin/answer.py?hl=en&answer=147837

And: http:// translate.google.com/toolkit/list? hl=en#translations/active

After Videha's objections, Google accepted, according to the author, that there is no language named "Bihari." "Maithili Wikipedia" had already been established by Videha, and Wikipedia had previously accepted the same point concerning "Bihari."

Google Maithili: Google Language Tools

http: //www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseActivity?project=gws&langcode=bh

Keep checking http://www.google.co.in/language_tools? hl=en for Maithili's availability.

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Another success for Videha — the Google search engine is now in Maithili. Google had earlier regarded it as the Bihari language, but after Videha objected, Google agreed that Maithili should have its own search engine. Wikipedia had already accepted this after Videha's objection. Here is the link: https://www.google.com/webhp? hl=bh. [Google had started a search engine named "Bihari," though no language by that name exists as a separate language. Someone translated "Bihari" as Angika, and the search engine appeared in Angika. Vinit Utpal of Videha then wrote the letter mentioned above. Videha volunteers did almost all the translation, and others were invited to participate, but contributions from outside were zero. The few who did contribute wrote in Roman script, which had to be corrected. Google is now displaying the search engine in Maithili, but much work still remains.]

See the Videha seminar discussion at
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I apologise for troubling you unnecessarily."

http://www.google.com/language_tools

Update: 28 March 2012.]

[Notice 1. Anshuman Pandey's application to encode both Kaithi and Mithilakshara in the Universal Character Set (Unicode) has been approved. The process of preparing Unicode fonts for both scripts has entered the queue; when their turn comes, work on their base fonts will begin. The base font for Mithilakshara will be named Tirhuta (just as the base font for Devanagari is Mangal and that for Bengali is Vrinda). The proposal for the Mithilakshara font was revised a third time. The second and third submissions discussed Videha's contribution in detail, for example: "Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22; Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http://www.videha.co.in/." Anshuman Pandey also wrote: "Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and

corresponded at length about Maithili, offered valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and provided feedback regarding requirements for the encoding of Maithili in the UCS."

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Contribute to Google Translate. When changing an edit, write in English, as the reason, that there is no language called "Bihari." Translate at this link after logging in through a Google account.
http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseActivity?project=gws&langcode=bh
To check whether Maithili is available, keep visiting
http://www.google.co.in/language_tools? hl=en.

Notice 3. Maithili Wikipedia —
Videha members have already translated 2,600 MediaWiki messages from English into Maithili. Now use http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special: Translate? task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai, go to Group, and select untranslated messages from the dropdown menu. If you are not a Wikipedia translator, request permission to translate into Maithili at http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project: Translator. First log in at the top right (or create an account), select Maithili in Preferences, click the link to your user account, and create your user page. After some time you should receive permission; then begin translating.
http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project: Translator
http://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Requests_for_new_languages/Wikipedia_Maithili
http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special: Translate?
task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai
http://incubator.wikimedia.org/wiki/Wp/mai
http://translatewiki.net/wiki/MediaWiki: Mainpage/mai

In Videha's third issue (1 February 2008), I had reported: "Wikipedia had articles about Maithili but no articles in Maithili, since a Maithili Wikipedia had not yet been approved. I had long been engaged in this effort, and am glad to announce that on 27 January 2008 permission was granted to begin a wiki for the Maithili language. Final approval, however, will come only if at least five people from different places regularly work as its editors." More than three years have now passed. All the preliminary requirements for Maithili Wikipedia have been fulfilled, and Wikipedia's Language Committee has understood that Maithili is not a language merely to be labelled "Bihari," and that it needs a separate Wikipedia.

Gerard M. of Wikipedia writes (http://ultimategerardm.blogspot.com/2011/05/bihari-wikipedia-is-actually-written-in.html):
"This information about Maithili and its relation to the Bihari languages was provided by Umesh Mandal. Umesh has been working on the Maithili localisation project on Wikipedia. ... The Language Committee was trying to ascertain whether Maithili could be placed within the Bihari language group. ... But Umesh's reply now makes it clear that the answer is 'no'."

Ramvilas Sharma wrote an article, "Maithili aur Hindi," in the Hindi monthly Patal, edited by Ramdayal Pandey, attempting to present Maithili as a dialect of Hindi. Yatri Ji opposed this in his own Hindi article at the age of forty-three (Aryavarta, 14/21 February 1954). Rajmohan Jha's Maithili translation appeared in the second issue of Arambh. Umesh Mandal's successful intervention has an additional distinction: he is only thirty. At a time when Maithils are employed in computer science from Hyderabad and Bangalore to Seattle, what does it indicate that this objection and correction came not from them, but from a young devotee of Maithili in a remote part of Mithila?

Umesh Mandal has also undertaken fieldwork to digitise, in audio and video, songs sung by members of every caste and religious community in Mithila. These recordings are available in the Videha archive.

TIRHUTA UNICODE
See Anshuman Pandey's final Unicode Mithilakshara application (5 May 2011): http://std.dkuug.dk/JTC1/SC2/WG2/docs/n4035.pdf. Page 23 includes an excerpt from the Tirhuta edition of Videha's eightieth issue as "Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22)." The references on page 12 include Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal, Issue 80 (15 April 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed.], http://www.videha.co.in/. On page 12 the editor's contribution is also acknowledged: "Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and corresponded at length about Maithili, offered valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and provided feedback regarding requirements for the encoding of Maithili in the UCS."]

Distribution of a leaflet on Unicode at a Sahitya Akademi story symposium (Gajendra Thakur; update of 31 March 2012)

Twitter in Maithili: Please visit http://translate.twttr.com/welcome, go to the bottom of the page, choose "Don't see your language? ... feedback,"

and submit a request for Maithili. Explain why Twitter is needed in Maithili, then send the feedback. Broad participation is requested.

Part Four

After Maithili on "Wikipedia," Maithili is now also on "Google Translate" ... the next goal is "Amazon Alexa"

Google Translate
Google Translate link: https://translate.google.com/?sl=en&tl=mai&op=translate
Contribute to strengthening Maithili in Google Translate: https://translate.google.com/about/contribute/
Earlier materials:
Wikipedia — 1 February 2008: https://books.google.co.in/books?id=VC-BD5Ad6z4C&lpg=PA1&pg=PA1#v=onepage&q&f=false (Maithili in Devanagari); https://books.google.co.in/books?id=cTezCU59bJwC&lpg=PP1&pg=PP1#v=onepage&q&f=false (Maithili in Tirhuta); https://books.google.co.in/books?id=3zKudz6wAO8C&lpg=PP1&pg=PP1#v=onepage&q&f=false (Maithili in Braille).
Google Translate — link dated 23 June 2011: https://www.facebook.com/groups/videha/permalink/138489416229195/
Videha members applied for a separate Maithili translation tool in Google Translation Tool, instead of the designation "Bihari." Contributors were urged to sign in with Google accounts and to explain in English, when giving reasons for edits, that "Bihari" is not a separate language. Earlier working links: http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseProject and http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseActivity?project=gws&langcode=bh (now closed).

Maithili Wikipedia links: Videha (journal): https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/kgv; Maithili Language in the World of the Internet: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/s6h; Bhalsari Tree: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/ipm; Videha: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/ie1; Videha Facebook Edition: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/iu1; Videha Honour: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/jc2; Videha Archive: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/jc0; Videha Mithila Ratna: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/jc3; Videha's Search for Mithila: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/jc4; Videha Information–Contact–Research: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/jc5; Shruti Prakashan: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/iu7; Anchinhar Akhar: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/ion; Maithili Ghazal: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/idz; Maithili Children's Ghazal: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/iex; Maithili Devotional Ghazal: https://mai.wikipedia.org/s/ifi; other contribution links:

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project: Translator;
http://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Requests_for_new_languages/Wikipedia_Maithili; http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special: Translate?task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai

http: //incubator. wikimedia. org/wiki/Wp/mai

The final five websites belong to the Maithili Wiki project. Visit these links and help advance the project. (Links closed.)

Amazon Alexa in Maithili (coming soon ...)

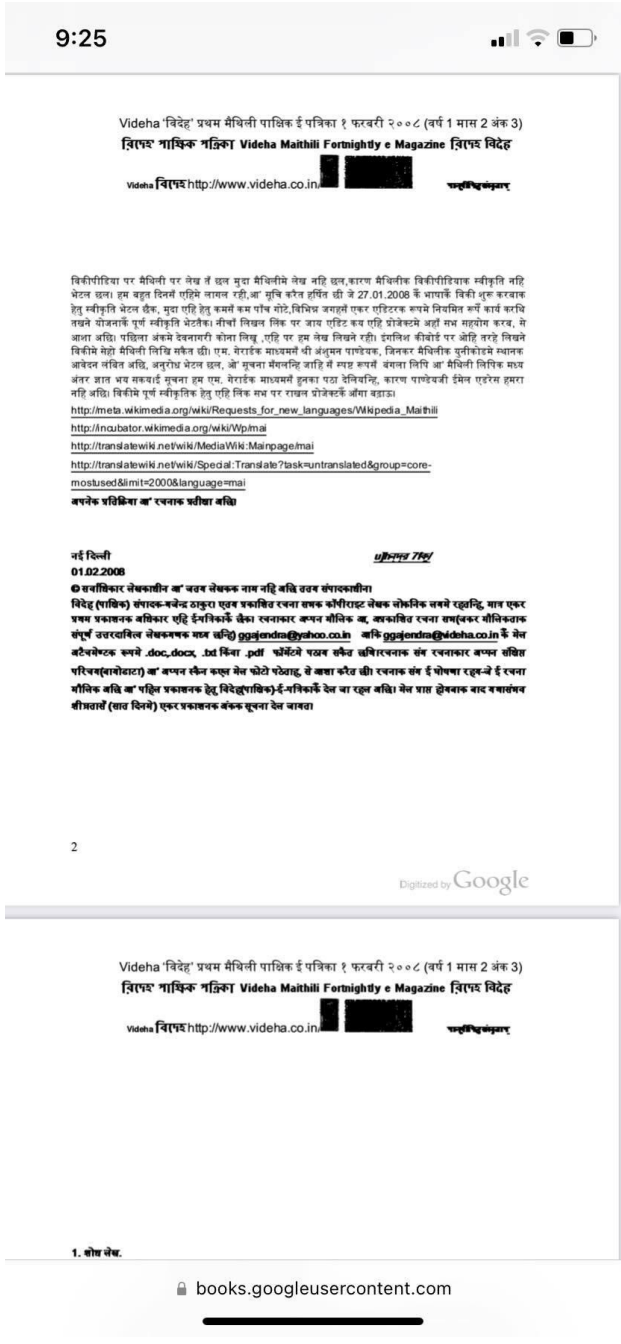
The good news concerning Maithili Wikipedia that was communicated to readers in Videha's third issue (1 February 2008) had yielded a happy outcome a few years earlier.

The favourable result of the initiative concerning Maithili on Google Translate, announced on Videha's Facebook page in 2011, came on 11 May 2022.

Maithili on Amazon Alexa, too, will begin soon.

(Links and screenshots are provided below.)

https://books.google.co.in/books? id=VC-BD5Ad6z4C&lpg=PA1&pg=PA2#v=onepage&q&f=false
https://www.facebook.com/groups/videha/permalink/1384894162291 95/



9:25

Videha 'विदेह' प्रथम मैथिली पाक्षिक ई पत्रिका १ फरबरी २००८ (वर्ष 1 मास 2 अंक 3)

विदेह साप्ताहिक पत्रिका Videha Maithili Fortnightly e Magazine विदेह विदेह

Videha विदेह http://www.videha.co.in/ [redacted] सम्पादक/प्रकाशक

विकीपीडिया पर मैथिली पर लेख तँ छल मुदा मैथिलीमे लेख नहि छल,कारण मैथिलीक विकीपीडियाक स्वीकृति नहि भेटल छल। हम बहुत दिनसँ एहिमे लागल रही,आ' सूचि करैत हर्षित छी जे 27.01.2008 कँ भाषाकेँ विकी शुरू करबाक हेतु स्वीकृति भेटल छैक, मुदा एहि हेतु कमसँ कम पाँच गोटे,विभिन्न जगहसँ एकर एडिटरक रूपमे नियमित रूपेँ कार्य करथि तखने योजनाकेँ पूर्ण स्वीकृति भेटतैक। नीचाँ लिखल लिंक पर जाय एडिट कय एहि प्रोजेक्टमे अहाँ सभ सहयोग करब, से आशा अछि। पहिला अंकमे देवनागरी कोना लिखू ,एहि पर हम लेख लिखने रही। इंगलिश कीबोर्ड पर ओहि तरहेँ लिखने विकीमे सेहो मैथिली लिखि सकैत छी। एम. गेराडक माध्यमसँ श्री अंशुमन पाण्डेयक, जिनकर मैथिलीक युनीकोडमे स्थानक आवेदन लंबित अछि, अनुरोध भेटल छल, ओ' सूचना मँगबानिह जाहि सँ स्पष्ट रूपसँ बंगला लिपि आ' मैथिली लिपिक मध्य अंतर ज्ञात भय सकय।ई सूचना हम एम. गेराडक माध्यमसँ हुनका पठा देलियनि, कारण पाण्डेयजी ईमेल एड्रेस हमरा नहि अछि। विकीमे पूर्ण स्वीकृतिक हेतु एहि लिंक सभ पर राखल प्रोजेक्टकेँ आँगा बढ़ाऊ।

http://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Requests_for_new_languages/Wikipedia_Maithili

http://incubator.wikimedia.org/wiki/Wp/mai

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/MediaWiki:Mainpage/mai

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special:Translate?task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai

अपनेक प्रतिक्रिया आ' रचनाक प्रतीक्षा अछि।

नई दिल्ली **धीरेन्द्र**

01.02.2008

© सर्वाधिकार लेखकाधीन आ' उचित लेखकक नाम नहि अछि उचित संपादकाधीन।

विदेह (पाक्षिक) संपादक-चन्देश्वर ठाकुर। एतय प्रकाशित रचना सभक कॉपीराइट लेखक लोकनिक लगमे रहलनि, मात्र एकर प्रथम प्रकाशनक अधिकार एहि ई-पत्रिकाकेँ छैक। रचनाकार अपन मौलिक आ, अप्रकाशित रचना सभ(जकर मौलिकताक संपूर्ण उत्तरदायित्व लेखकमात्रक गछ छनि) ggajendra@yahoo.co.in वाकिं ggajendra@videha.co.in कँ मेल अटैचमेण्टक रूपमे .doc,.docx, .txt किंवा .pdf फॉर्मेटमे पठाय सकैत छथिरचनाक संग रचनाकार अपन संक्षिप्त परिचय(बायोडाटा) आ' अपन स्कैन कएल मेल फोटो पठेबाहु, से आशा करैत छी। रचनाक संग ई घोषणा रहब-जे ई रचना मौलिक अछि आ' पहिल प्रकाशनक हेतु विदेह(पाक्षिक)-ई-पत्रिकाकेँ देल जा रहल अछि। मेल प्राप्त होयबाक बाद यथासंभव शीघ्रातिशीघ्र (सात दिनमे) एकर प्रकाशनक अंकक सूचना देल जायत।

2

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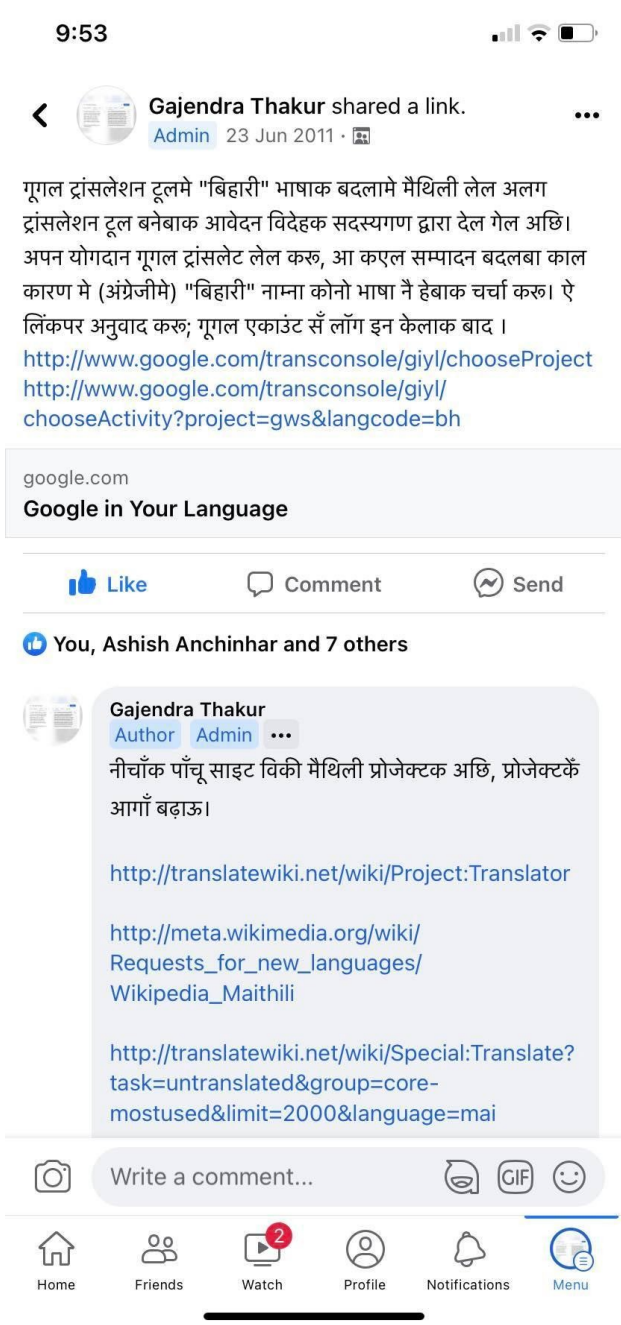
Videha 'विदेह' प्रथम मैथिली पाक्षिक ई पत्रिका १ फरबरी २००८ (वर्ष 1 मास 2 अंक 3)

विदेह साप्ताहिक पत्रिका Videha Maithili Fortnightly e Magazine विदेह विदेह

Videha विदेह http://www.videha.co.in/ [redacted] सम्पादक/प्रकाशक

1. शोध लेख.

books.googleusercontent.com


9:53
Gajendra Thakur shared a link.
Admin 23 Jun 2011 ·
गूगल ट्रांसलेशन टूलमे "बिहारी" भाषाक बदलामे मैथिली लेल अलग ट्रांसलेशन टूल बनेबाक आवेदन विदेहक सदस्यगण द्वारा देल गेल अछि। अपन योगदान गूगल ट्रांसलेट लेल करू, आ कएल सम्पादन बदलबा काल कारण मे (अंग्रेजीमे) "बिहारी" नाम्ना कोनो भाषा नै हेबाक चर्चा करू। ऐ लिंकपर अनुवाद करू; गूगल एकाउंट सँ लॉग इन केलाक बाद ।
http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseProject
http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseActivity?project=gws&langcode=bh
google.com
Google in Your Language
Like
Comment
Send
You, Ashish Anchinhar and 7 others
Gajendra Thakur
Author Admin
नीचाँक पाँचू साइट विकी मैथिली प्रोजेक्टक अछि, प्रोजेक्टकेँ आगाँ बढ़ाऊ।
http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project:Translator
http://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Requests_for_new_languages/Wikipedia_Maithili
http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special:Translate?task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai
Write a comment...
GIF
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Friends
Watch
Profile
Notifications
Menu

At that time the Videha editorial board comprised the following members. Associate Editor: Umesh Mandal. Assistant Editors: Shiv Kumar Jha and

Munnaji (Manoj Kumar Karna). Language Editing: Nagendra Kumar Jha and genealogist Vidyanand Jha. Art Editing: Vanita Kumari and Rashmi Rekha Sinha. Research and Investigation Editors: Dr Jaya Verma and Dr Rajiv Kumar Verma. Drama, Theatre and Cinema Editor: Bechan Thakur. Information, Liaison and News Editors: Poonam Mandal and Priyanka Jha. Translation Department Editor: Vinit Utpal. It is clear that Vinit Utpal, the Translation Department Editor (now Assistant Professor at IIMC Jammu), made a particularly important contribution. Ashish Anchinhar, although not formally on the editorial board, did no less work than any editor. Maithili's readers also contributed according to their abilities.
https://books.google.co.in/books?id=zmIugpjpOKYC&lpg=PA1&pg=PA600#v=onepage&q&f=false
https://books.google.co.in/books? id=-U04e5FfnTEC&lpg=PA1&pg=PA405#v=onepage&q&f=false

Google Translate needs to be strengthened further. Accordingly, we are taking forward the next task:
https://translate.google.com/about/contribute/

Watch the Google Translate programme.

https://youtu.be/nP-nMZpLM1A
Google Translate: from 04:45 to 06:25; at 06:00, twenty-four new languages.

For a detailed account, watch this keynote to learn how the aim of organising the world's information and making it universally accessible and useful is being pursued. Version with American Sign Language (ASL) interpretation: https://youtu.be/PeUXBvRExic. Timeline — 0:00 opening film; 1:47 introduction, Sundar Pichai; 6:21 knowledge; 15:45 knowledge and search; 27:15 Skin Tone Equity; 32:00 computing; 33:08 Assistant; 43:34 computing — AI Test Kitchen; 53:08 safety with Google; 1:04:38 safer search; 1:11:20 Android begins; 1:25:32 Android — Better Together; 1:45:45 Wear OS and Tablet; 1:31:22 hardware begins; 1:33:22 Pixel Phone and Buds; 1:45:44 Ambient and Beyond the Phone; 1:54:32 Augmented Reality and conclusion.

SECTION B — ESSAYS

28. Before Writing a Literary Work...

Abstract

A composition arranged in metre is called verse; otherwise it is prose. Chhand, or metre, signifies a composition that affords delight. This does not mean, however, that contemporary new poetry must be classified as prose. Even the Vedic Sāvitrī-Gāyatrī mantra is counted as Gāyatrī metre under flexible or liberal rules. This will be discussed below: for example, when the required syllables are not present, one or two syllables may be supplied in each pāda, or metrical quarter.

Keywords: composition · before writing · critical theory · Maithili

Literature has two forms, prose and verse. A composition arranged in metre is verse; otherwise it is prose. Chhand means a composition that gives delight. One should not infer from this that the new poetry of our time belongs to prose, for the Vedic Sāvitrī-Gāyatrī mantra itself is reckoned as Gāyatrī metre under flexible or liberal rules. This will be discussed later: if the required syllables are incomplete, one or two are added to each pāda. Conjuncts containing ya and va are separated by inserting i and u respectively, as in the following examples:

वरेण्यम् = वरेणियम्

स्वः = सुवः.

For modern poetry, as well as for haiku, kṣaṇikā and haikū, Maithili and the Indian writing systems derived from Sanskrit are particularly suitable. Apart from Tamil, the scripts of southern India and the north-western and eastern regions, including Devanagari, have corresponding vowel and consonant arrangements—the ka, ca, ṭa, ta and pa groups—in which what is written is pronounced. Short i in Devanagari, however, is an exception: its sign is written before the consonant, though pronounced after it. In Maithili, we may conclude, even this exception does not apply. Thus अछि is pronounced with the short a and i in relation to ch, or as a-i-ch; similarly, राति is read rā-i-ta. The conclusion, therefore, is that Maithili is an especially suitable language for haiku. Consider another example. Sandhi is characteristic of Sanskrit, but is English devoid of sandhi? What, then, is the spoken sequence “I'm going towards the end”? It is written “I am going towards the end.” Pāṇini formulated sandhi rules on the basis of phonetics. In written English, those rules are not followed as they are in Sanskrit, although “I am” becomes “I'm” phonetically and such joining occurs in speech. In Maithili too, case particles are, wherever possible, written and pronounced attached to the word.

Metres are of two kinds: mātrā-based metres and syllabic, or varṇa-based, metres.

The Vedas employ syllabic metres, not mātrā-based metres.

In a varṇic metre only the number of varṇas, or syllabic units, is counted. A consonant marked with the halant is not counted separately. A syllable bearing e, u or another vowel sign is counted as one, as is a conjunct consonant. Each character from अ to ह् likewise receives a count of one; no varṇa or syllabic unit has a value greater than one. Keep three general principles in mind:

1. A halant-marked consonant: 0.

2. A conjunct character: 1.

3. Each character from अ through ह: 1.

Now consider the first example:

ई अरदराक मेघ नहि मानत रहत बरसि के = 1 + 5 + 2 + 2 + 3 + 3 + 1 = 17.

Now consider a second example:

पश्चात् = 2.

Now consider a third example:

आब = 2.

Now consider a fourth example:

स्क्रिप्ट = 2.

There are seven principal Vedic metres:

Gāyatrī, Uṣṇik, Anuṣṭubh, Bṛhatī, Paṅkti, Triṣṭubh and Jagatī. The remaining forms are their variations, including atichhand and vichhand. Here metres are identified by syllables. If the syllable count is deficient, one or two syllables may be added to each pāda. Conjuncts containing ya and va are separated by the addition of i and u respectively, as follows:

वरेण्यम् = वरेणियम्.

स्वः = सुवः.

The syllable count may also be completed by separating the products of guṇa and vṛddhi.

ए = अ + इ.

ओ = अ + उ.

ऐ = अ/आ + ए.

औ = अ/आ + ओ.

We should now become acquainted with the concepts of guru and laghu as employed in the science of prosody, or Chhandaḥśāstra.

Among the thirteen vowels, अ, इ, उ, ऋ and ऌ are identified as the five short vowels, while आ, ई, ऊ, ॠ, ए, ऐ, ओ and औ are listed as the eight long vowels.

When these vowels are joined to consonants they produce modified consonantal syllables, termed guṇitākṣara.

क् + अ = क.

क् + आ = का.

A vowel unit or one such modified consonantal unit is called an akṣara, or syllable. A bare consonant is not itself treated as a syllable. Thus अवाक् contains two syllables, अ and वा.

1. All short vowels, and consonantal syllables bearing short vowels, are laghu (light). They are indicated by U written above the unit.

2. All long vowels, and consonantal syllables bearing long vowels, are guru (heavy). They are indicated by a short horizontal stroke above the unit.

3. Every syllable containing anusvāra or visarga is considered guru.

4. A syllable followed by a conjunct consonant or a bare consonant is regarded as guru. For example, in अच् and सत्य, the अ and स respectively are heavy.

5. Just as varṇic metres were used in the Vedas, the study of vocal accent had also developed in that period. In broad outline the accents are classified as: (1) udātta, (2) udāttatara, (3) anudātta, (4) anudāttatara, (5) svarita, (6) anudāttānurakta-svarita and (7) pracaya. The last is described as a form of śruti or unstruck sound (anāhata nāda), arising without the collision of objects, whereas the others are struck sounds (āhata nāda), produced by contact.

1. Udātta: vowels such as a pronounced in the upper part of the throat or other articulatory positions; no mark is assigned. 2. Udāttatara: pronounced still higher in the throat and associated positions. 3. Anudātta: pronounced in the lower region of those positions, with an oblique sign beneath. 4. Anudāttatara: pronounced from an exceptionally low position. 5. Svarita: an accent combining an anudātta portion with an udātta

portion, represented by a vertical stroke above. 6. Anudāttānurakta-svarita: a form in which udātta, svarita or both follow; it has three varieties. 7. Pracaya: where an anudātta follows a svarita, there arises a sustained, unstruck resonance, or pracaya.

1. The Pūrvārcika contains, in sequence, chants addressed to Agni, Indra and Soma Pavamāna. There follow the Āraṇyaka Kāṇḍa and the Mahānāmnī Ārcika. The Āgneya, Aindra and Pāvamāna sections are also called Grāmageya-gāna, while the remaining part of the Pūrvārcika is called Āraṇyaka-gāna. Collectively these constitute Prakṛti-gāna. 2. The Uttarārcika is also called Vikṛti or Uttara-gāna. Mantras selected from Grāmageya-gāna and Āraṇyaka-gāna become, respectively, Ūha-gāna and Ūhya-gāna. Each collection is further divided into Daśarātra, Saṃvatsara, Ekāha, Ahīna, Prāyaścitta and Kṣudra sections. Melodies remembered from the Pūrvārcika are applied in the Uttarārcika to groupings of two, three or four mantras (dvika, trika and catuṣṭaka). In most such groupings the first mantra comes from the Pūrvārcika, and its melody serves for the entire hymn or grouped sequence.

The Uttarārcika, Ūha-gāna and Ūhya-gāna render each melody three times and in three ways. In Vedic ritual the prastāva is sung by the prastotṛ; the udgītha by the udgātṛ; the pratihāra by the pratihartṛ; the upadrava again by the udgātṛ; and the nidhana jointly by all three. Before the prastāva, the three chant the hiṃkāra—hiṃ, huṃ, haṃ—and the udgātṛ chants Oṃ before the udgītha. These are the five bhaktis, or divisions.

Hand gestures: 1.1. The thumb (first digit) held a distance of one barley-grain away. 2.2. The thumb touching the first finger. 3.3. The thumb touching the middle finger. 4.4. The thumb touching the fourth finger. 5.5. The thumb touching the fifth finger. 6.11. The sixth, kruṣṭa: the thumb two barley-grains from the first finger. 7.6. The seventh, atisvara, of the Sāmaveda. 8.7. Abhigīta of the Ṛgveda.

Grāmageya singing was performed in villages and public places. Āraṇyaka-gāna was performed in forests and sacred places.

Ūha-gāna was used in Soma sacrifices and special religious observances, drawing upon the Grāmageya chants associated with the Pūrvārcika. Ūhya-gāna, or Rahasya-gāna, was sung in forests and sacred places and was associated with the Āraṇyaka chants of the Pūrvārcika. The Nāradiya Śikṣā gives the following figures for Sāma singing: 1. svara, 7; grāma, 3; mūrcchanā, 21; tāna, 49.

The seven notes are sa, re, ga, ma, pa, dha and ni, and the three grāmas are madhya, manda and tīvra. Seven times three yields twenty-one mūrcchanās; combinations of the seven notes yield seven times seven, or forty-nine tānas.

Every Ṛgvedic mantra is treated as equivalent to three mantras on account of Gautama's two Sāma chants (parka) and Kāśyapa's one Sāma chant (parka). Macdonell treats Indrāgnī, Mitrāvaruṇau, Indrāviṣṇū and Agnīṣomau as paired deities. Yet the paired deity is understood in terms of a reversal of qualifying terms.

Vedic recitation:

1. Saṃhitā-pāṭha is recitation in its continuous, unbroken form.

अग्निमीळे पुरोहितं यज्ञस्यदेवमृत्विजम। होतारंरत्न धातमम्।

2. Pada-pāṭha: each word is read separately.

3. Krama-pāṭha: the first word is read with the second, then the second with the third, the third with the fourth, and so on.

4. Jaṭā-pāṭha: if the three words are a, b and c, the sequence is ab, ba, ab, bc, cb, bc. 5. Ghana-pāṭha: according to the example supplied here, the sequence is ab, ba, abc, cba, abc. 6. Mālā; 7. Śikhā; 8. Rekhā; 9. Dhvaja; 10. Daṇḍa; 11. Ratha. The last eight methods are known collectively as the aṣṭavikṛtis.

There are also six transformations of Sāma singing, permitting shortening or lengthening in the interests of melody. 1. Vikāra: changing agne to ognāya. 2. Viśleṣaṇa: separating a word or constituent. 3. Vikarṣaṇa: drawing out a note or pronouncing it for a greater number of beats. 4. Abhyāsa: repetition. 5. Virāma: breaking a word by introducing a pause (yati) within it. 6. Stobha: adding an expression suitable for melodic elaboration. The Kauthuma branch adds "hāu" and "rāi," whereas the Rāṇāyanīya branch adds "hāvu" and "rāyi."

The Vedas employ varṇic metres rather than mātrā-based metres, counting by pāda or metrical quarter. Gāyatrī is the principal and most frequently used metre, followed by Triṣṭubh and Jagatī.

1. Gāyatrī: three pādas of eight syllables each, with a pause after the second pāda; alternatively, six syllables in a pāda.

2. Triṣṭubh: four pādas of eleven syllables each.

3. Jagatī: four pādas of twelve syllables each.

4. Uṣṇik: two pādas of eight syllables followed by one of twelve.

5. Anuṣṭubh: four pādas of eight syllables each; it is used more frequently in Sanskrit literature than in the Vedas.

6. Bṛhatī: two pādas of eight, followed by two pādas of twelve and eight units respectively.

7. Paṅkti: five pādas of eight syllables each, with a pause after the first two.

If the syllable count is incomplete, one or two syllables can be added or subtracted in the following ways:

(a) वरेण्यम् becomes वरेणियम्; स्वः becomes सुवः.

(b) Guṇa and vṛddhi sandhi may be resolved into their components.

ए = अ + इ.

ओ = अ + उ.

ऐ = अ/आ + ए.

औ = अ/आ + ओ.

If this still does not complete the count, the resulting forms receive other designations, such as Virāṭ.

For example, within the Gāyatrī group (24 syllables): Virāṭ (22), Nicṛt (23), Śuddhā (24), Bhurik (25) and Svarāṭ (26).

ॐ भूर्भुवस्वः। तत् सवितुर्वरेण्यं। भर्गो देवस्य धीमहि। धियो यो नः प्रचोदयात्।

The Vedic seers call themselves poets, and they also call the deities poets. The entire corpus of Vedic literature is a verbal embodiment of this poetic consciousness. There spiritual awareness rises to the plane of the divine and is given expression in the language of material existence.

We now turn to the vocabularies of Jyotirishwar, Vidyapati, Chatur Chaturbhuj and Badrinath Jha, with the aim of improving the reader's skill in writing.

1. The Vocabulary of Kaviśekhara Jyotirishwar

गोण्ठि — boatman or fisher-boatman

कबार — vegetable vendor

पटनिआ — boatman

लबाल — a garrulous or loose-tongued person

लौजिह — one whose tongue is eager with desire; greedy

पेटकट — one whose stomach has been cut, or who cuts into another's livelihood

नाकट — a person with a cut-off nose

बएर — jujube fruit

बाबुर — the babul tree

खुसा — dry, withered

चुसा — something to be sucked

फरुही — puffed or parched rice

करहर — the edible rhizome of the water lily

मलैचा — chilli pepper

बोबलि — an edible tuber, also known as ghechuli

बाँसी — a flute

हुलुक — the hudukka, a musical instrument

जोहारि — a greeting or salutation

तोरह — weigh it

बराबह — set it apart, separating it into pieces

खुटी — an ear ornament worn by women on the upper part of the ear

सिङ्कली — a chain

चुलि — a bangle

त्रिका — an ornament worn along the parting of the hair

खञ्जरीट — the khanjan or wagtail bird

साँकर — sugar; also identified as a red cane

बिरनी — a braid or knot of hair

कम्बु — a conch shell

पञ्ज — a lotus

राउत — a military officer

राजशिष्ट — a courtier of the king

पुरपति — the head of a town or city

साधि — a wealthy merchant

गन्धवणिक — a perfume seller dealing in musk and other fragrances

बेलवार — a border guard

राजपुत्र — an official bearing the title rājaputra

द्वारिक — the official who authorises entry into the royal court

पनिहार — a gatekeeper

अगहरा — a person who performs duties on receiving an agrahāra grant

रौतपति/राजपुत्रपति — the chief of the rauts

सन्धिविग्रहिक — a minister responsible for foreign affairs

महामहत्तक — the minister responsible for defence

प्रतिबलकरणाध्यक्ष — the department concerned with spying on enemy forces

स्थानान्तरिक — an officer responsible for arrangements during the king's travels

नैबन्धिक — a writer or recorder of documents

वार्तिक — a collector of secret intelligence; vārtika and mahāvārtika are high titles in the genealogical register

आक्षपटलिक — an official of the gambling house

खड्गग्राह — a sword-bearing guard protecting the king

प्रमत्त्वार — an official charged with restraining mad persons

बिश्वास — the king's trusted personal attendant

अग्रजाणिक — the security party marching ahead of the king on a journey

गूढ पुरुष — a secret agent

प्रणिधि — a secret agent

वार्तिक — a spy

सूपकार — a cook

सूपकारपति — the chief cook

सम्बाहक — an attendant to the cook

बलिष्ठ — a physically powerful bodyguard, or baithā

श्रोत्रिय — a scholar of the Vedas

आध्यायिक — a student or scholar

मौहूर्तिक — an astrologer

आम्नायिक — an adviser on warfare belonging to Vedic or Tantric learning

चूड़ामणि — the art or science of divination

पँचरुखी काँच — a prism, described as five-faced glass

महथ — a high military rank; also mahathā, mehtā or mahto

मुदहथ — the person entrusted with the king's seal

महसाहनि — a supply officer

महसुआर — the chief cook

महल — mahar, a prosperous cattle-keeper, as in Nanda Mahar

सेजवार — the keeper of the royal bed or sleeping arrangements

पनहरि — a bearer of betel

राजवल्लभ — a courtier

भण्डारी — a storehouse or treasury officer

कलबार — a merchant

चोरगाहा — a person who waves the ceremonial yak-tail fan

सुखासन — a comfortable chair

चौपाड़ि — an outer room, veranda or teaching hall

अँचरा — a shoulder cloth or gamchhā

समरहर — body massage

विदान — physical exercise, said to have thirty-six forms

तमारु — a copper water vessel

पनिगह — a vessel for pouring or casting out water

तमकुण्ड — a deep copper vessel

अप्यायक — satisfying or refreshing

फेना — a sweet preparation made with boiled sugar

जेञोनार — a feast

स्वर्गदुर्लभ — betel leaf, called a delight rare even in heaven

दण्डिया — the portion above the staff or pole

भृङ्गार — a golden pitcher

आरहल — began or commenced

किटाएल — became angry

नियोगी — a kind of faqir or mendicant

बुसक — of husk or chaff

धुनि — an open fire or hearth

संकोच — becoming smaller; contraction

अपगत — unnoticed

सम्भार — expansion or spreading

कौशिक — an owl

गोमायु — a jackal

नओबति — a watch or guard party

चतुःसम — a liquid used for plastering an interior surface

माठ — a kind of khājā confection

उनच — a sheet or cloth spread out as bedding

दर्दुर — a frog

झिकरुआ — a cricket or chirping insect

निविल — very dense or thick

काकोल — a black crow

कोल — a pig

शिवा — a female jackal

फेत्कार — barking

प्रसारी — motionless clouds

अखलु — it appears or seems

अखउलि — said earlier

वारिभक्त — cooked rice left overnight in water

सौहित्य — satiety or satisfaction

उपचय — increase or growth

पाण्डुरता — whiteness, as when clouds turn from dark to white in autumn

प्रसन्नता — clearness or purity

सफरी — the poṭhī fish

तरङ्ग — restlessness or movement

शालि — rice plants bowed with grain-filled ears

मरुआ — a flowering shrub of the tulsi type

विशेषकच्छेद — painting designs with musk on the forehead and cheeks

दर्शनविधि — colouring the teeth and lips

वसनविधि — dyeing cloth

वर्णिकाविधि — painting pictures

शेखरयोजन — arranging or tying the hair in a bun

पत्रभङ्ग — applying musk designs or paste to the body

गन्धयुक्ति — preparing scented oils and perfumes

पानककरनी — preparing sherbet

पट्टिकावान — weaving a mat

तर्कुकर्म — craftwork with sīkī grass

आकरज्ञान — knowledge of the earth; geology

अक्षरमुष्टिका — communicating letters and meanings through finger signs

दोहदकरण — inducing a tree to flower during scarcity by artificial treatment

छलितयोग — a particular form of yoga

रसवाद — chemical science or alchemy

दुकूल — fabric used for a veil or head covering

क्षौम — cloth made from flax fibre

कौशेय — tussar silk made from an insect cocoon

कमरूबाल — a person from Kāmarūpa

बङ्गाल — a person from Bengal

गुञ्जर — a Gurjar

कठिबाल — a person from Kathiawar

बरहथी — twelve cubits long

बैङ्गना — of the colour of a brinjal or aubergine

पञ्चहर — a palace divided into five sections

पञ्चसम — a powder of five fragrant substances

प्रदीपकलस — an auspicious lamp placed in a pot and shielded from the wind

षेमा — a temporary encampment of the king and his army

वारिगह — an elephant or horse stable

एकचोइ/दोचोइ — a tent with one or two principal poles

मण्डबा — a wedding pavilion or temporary canopy

कपलघड़ — a house or shelter made of cloth

बरागन — a term explained as bairāgan, with Soma, Ravi and others named as examples

चेष्टसार — a gambling hall

सहिआर — an umpire

खेलबार — the proprietor of a gambling house

दण्डसाह — a witness to a penalty or judicial punishment

कात — a stake in winning or losing; also lustre

उपनय — bringing near

भुजङ्ग — a messenger or gossip who carries tales

घल — a crowd or cluster

अगिरानि — an advance-guard unit

सेनगाह — a commander of the army

रजाएस — a royal order

घोल — a horse

पाएन — a ring or loop for resting the foot

पलानि — tightening a saddled horse's equipment

थलबार — a groom who tends horses in a stable

पाग — a turban or headcloth

सरमोजा — a cap or knitted head covering

गान्ती — a knot or tie

बाग — a whip

साङ्कल — a chain or connecting link

डाम्भ — a tender green coconut

फरेन्द — a segment or slice

कोन्ते — a spear

लउली — a staff or stick

जाठी — a staff or pole of the kind called phaṛāṭhī

कोन्तिआ — a spearman

धमसा — a large kettle-drum

महुअरि — a wind instrument played by blowing

अनायत — helpless or deaf,

षतबार — a guard or sentry

बाइति — the sound of a musical instrument

टाप — the impact or beat of a horse's hoof

मुहरव — a sound made with the mouth

पलानि — tightly fastened

करुअक — did or performed

सर्वांवसर — an open or general royal audience

वेकल्हेण्टे — a waist or lower back

पाट — silken

धलि — a dhariyā or kappā cloth

पाझि — a bird

टोपर — a cap-shaped cover

सइचान — a falcon or hawk

पितशाल — a kind of tree identified as pīrā sāṅkhu

सरल — a fragrant coniferous tree or incense wood called saraṛ

सिम्बलि — the silk-cotton tree

सिंसप — the shisham tree

सहोल — the sal tree

पाउलि — a tree known locally as pāṅḍari

बंझि — barren or sterile

गिरिछ — a bear

गुआ — areca nut or betel nut

नरङ्ग — an orange

नमेरु — a rudrākṣa seed

बउर — the bakul or mālsarī tree

छोलङ्ग — a dried date

जुड़ — cool or refreshing

एला — cardamom

सुखमेला — small cardamom

मधुकर — the medicinal plant śatāvarī

कम्पूर कदली — a fragrant variety of banana, kapūr-kadalī

कपिञ्जल — a partridge

धारागृह — a bathing chamber with fountains or showers

स्थेय — one who does not flee

परम्परीण — handed down through generations

पुरुष — a guard or soldier

कार — black

काबर — mottled or spotted

चलक — a pale or white colour, called charak

गोल — fair or light-coloured

कइल — tawny or light brown

पाण्डर — pale or whitish

शीकरविक्षेप — spraying a fountain or scattering fine droplets

गण्डूष — a mouthful of water used for rinsing

नाकजलबुद्बुद — blowing air through the nose into water to make bubbles

पिण्ड — a stool or small seat

पारी — an enclosure or surrounding hedge

साटि — a peg or post

चुत — a mango

पस्रवण — a spring or source of water

पहाल — a mountain

डोङ्कल — a hill

चुली — a summit or peak

कोइआर — the kovidāra tree

सैम्ब — the silk-cotton tree

सीसमु — the shisham tree

साङ्कु — the sal tree

समि — a tree also known as śani or sainī

सहोल — the sāhoṛ tree

पञोकठ — lotus wood

सभर — the sambar deer, also called aṣṭāpada deer

कुटुम्बिनी — a bird known as khīrī

कठहरिआ — a woodpecker

पेच — an owl

स्रुच — a wooden ladle or ritual spoon

पञ्चामृत — the five nectars: curd, milk, clarified butter, honey and sugar

पञ्चकषाय — a powder of five fragrant substances applied to the body

चषाल — the rounded cap at the top of a sacrificial post

उदूखल — a mortar

चमस — a bowl

संभृति — materials or provisions

सप्तधान्य — seven grains: barley, wheat, sesame, kāun, sām, chīna and nīvāra

आषाढ़दण्ड — a staff made of palāśa wood

तरुत्वच — tree bark used as clothing

वृक्षी — a seat upon which a sage sits

दारुपात्र — a wooden vessel or trough

करण्डक — a basket

बह्आरि — a daughter-in-law

बिदान — a wrestling trick or stance

उभरि — leaping upwards; a wrestling manoeuvre

अवधा — a downward-facing position; a wrestling manoeuvre

विद्यावन्ति — a female dancer

सोताक ककना — a marriage necklace or maṅgalasūtra

सिङ्कली — a chain

शाख — a conch-shell bangle

खुन्ती — an ornament worn on the upper ear

चूलि — a bangle

तृका — an ornament worn in the parting of the hair

दशजुधि — the daśauṃhī, a person who announces to the king the passing of time; now associated with a bard

समहथ — simultaneously striking musical instruments with the hands to produce a unified sound

मण्डल — a circular movement of the hands and feet that carries the performer from one posture to another

अङ्गहार — gracefully placing the limbs in their proper positions

भाल — a stove or hearth called bhūjābālā

ओबारी — a cooking pot

शिवा — a female jackal

भीम — terrifying

उल्कामुख — a variety of jackal said to emit flames from its mouth

जन्ताक — a hand-operated grinding mill

चुञ्ची — a breast

पसार — a shop

पेचा — an owl

षीषील — a small creature called khikhīṛ

नेउर — a mongoose

अपर्यन्त — without limit; boundless

पाट — a silk garment

कापल — cloth

सकलात — a carpet

दुसुखासन — a comfortable bed

लचसूचिका — a bedcover woven on nine needles

परिकर-नायक — the leader of an entourage or group

वर्हि — kuśa grass

समिध — fuel wood for a ritual fire

दृषद — a stone

लाज — popped or parched rice

इष्टाङ्गना — the woman intended to become one's wife

सुरती — originally something from Surat; now a term for chewing tobacco from Surat

जातीफल — nutmeg

सूक्ष्मेला — small cardamom

गुलत्वक — cinnamon bark

पत्रक — bay leaf

पिर्प्पली — long pepper

कटुकी ओ दुलाह — two medicinal herbs, identified as kaṭukī and dulāh/dulār kāṇṭ

मूल्य परिच्छेद — bargaining over or settling the price

निष्क्रय — exchange or barter

कर्षक्रय — buying a gold coin

अङ्कपरिस्थिति — keeping accounts

हरण-भरण — receiving and delivering goods

व्यवच्छेद — making a settlement or deciding a dispute

नष्टकाक — a black crow

सलभ — a moth or flying insect

ग्रहिल — one who clings or is attached

सद्विचक्षण — a discerning and learned person

वपा — a mound of earth shaped like a crowd or heap

खोल — a pit or hollow

हस्तकाण्ड — a long pole

गुणकाण्ड — a pole used for measurement

वत्सदन्त — shaped like a calf's tooth

भल्ल नख — resembling a bear's claw

तृपर्व — having three joints or segments

सप्तपर्व — having seven joints or segments

आलीढ़ — the ālīḍha stance: standing with the right knee raised and the left knee lowered and planted

प्रत्यालीढ़ — pratyālīḍha: the reverse of the ālīḍha stance

समपाद — samapāda: standing with both knees aligned in a straight line

बिशाख — viśākha: standing with both legs spread apart

स्थानक — a standing posture

असन — a spear

गोकर्ण — a short spear

मुकुल — an arrow shaped like a flower bud

डाण्ड — an oar, or a wooden vessel for bailing water

चाड, चडक — a group or fleet of boats

जुज्झार — a warrior or fighting infantryman

गणक — a mathematician

तारावि्द् — one who determines direction by observing the stars

गुणवृक्ष — a ship's mast

सेकपात्र — a wooden vessel used for bailing water from a boat

वोहित — a fleet of ships

बिआरी — an evening meal

चोरगाहि — a woman who carries or waves a ceremonial yak-tail fan

पटा — a small low stool

बधा — wooden sandals with pegs are called kharāūṃ; with straps they are called badhā

तमारु — a copper plate

बटइ — a quail

तेरिआ — a three-posted arrangement; also a buffalo that has calved twice,

लेबारी — stalks and straw

अधतेरह — half less than thirteen, that is, twelve and a half

अँचओलनि — washed the hands and face

देवरूपा — a kind of silver

2. Vidyapati's Vocabulary

मृगमद — musk

वासर — day

रैन — night

लिधुर — blood

पुर नटी — an accomplished urban actress or dancing woman

अवतरु — descend; become incarnate

कनक भूधर — Mount Sumeru

चन्द्रिका चय — a mass of moonlight

निपातिनि — she who destroys

भक्त भयापनोदन — she who dispels the fears of devotees

दुरित हारिणि — she who removes the burden of misfortune

दुर्गमारि — a formidable enemy

विमर्द — destroyed

गाहिनी — she who wanders

सायक — an arrow

सुकर — beautiful

पिसित — raw flesh

पारणा — satisfaction; fulfilment

रभसे — she who gladdens

कृशानु — fire

चुम्ब्यमान — is kissing

परिच्युति — destroys

आड़ — red

भागि — curved

गोए — in concealment; having hidden

सुधाए — nectar; ambrosia

कुशेशय — the hundred-petalled lotus

अधबोली — an unfinished utterance

खनेखन — from moment to moment

उचिक — in astonishment

आरति — pain; distress

अनानि — ignorant

दन्द — quarrel

हेरैत — looking; seeing

मनसिज — Kāmadeva, the god of love

गौरव — weight; gravity

खीन — weakened; emaciated

अओके — belonging to another

लहु — small; light

परगास — light; illumination

सुरत विहार — amorous play

नवरङ्ग — orange (the fruit)

सन्तापलि — causing suffering

बाङ्क — bent; curved

पसाह — adornment; toilet preparations

भीति — out of fear

तिष — sharp; keen

सिझल — accomplished; brought to completion

कोरि — the fruit of the jujube tree

ससन — wind; air

धनि — the heroine

अम्बर — clothing; a garment

रेह — a line

रङ्ग — delight

अलका — an unguent; an application

मसि — ink

समरा — dark-complexioned

कचोरा — a bowl

पहू — lord; master

ससधर — the moon

मनोभव — Kāmadeva, the god of love

सउदामिनी — lightning

करिनि — a female elephant

वयन — face

परिमल — fragrance

तनरुचि — the fair complexion of the body

अरुझायल — entangled

बिलास-कानन — a pleasure-garden

निविल — dense; thick

विहि — fate; providence

निज — one's own

विद्रुम दले — on a petal of the mausari plant

तिहुअन — the three worlds

मल्ल — a wrestler

हाटक — gold

थम्भ — a pillar

चिकुर-निकर — a mass of hair; a tress

विचरित — contrary to the prescribed rule

कवरी — a tress of hair

चामरि — the yak from which a fly-whisk is made

सम्भसि — conversation; speaking together

न जासि — cannot be done

हुतासे — fire

मो — I; me

पीहलि — covered over

पीहित — covered; concealed

कुहुकि — a sorceress; a woman of illusion

जुड़ायब — to cool; to make cool

दहइ — to burn

अवनत — bent downward

बारल — prevented; warded off

धाओल — ran forward

पसाहिम — adornment

फुलग — a thrill; horripilation

बलाअ — a bracelet; a ring-shaped ornament

पेखलि — saw

बेढ़लि — enveloped; wrapped around

थीर — steady; motionless

पुछसि — you ask

परस — touch

झुरए — grows restless

अम्बुद — a rain-cloud

धन्दा — doubt

पुतलि — an image; an idol

इन्दु — the moon

महि — the earth

माझ — the middle

खिन — weakened; thin

मधु — flower nectar

उपेखि — having disregarded; with neglect

तरुअर — a tree

लेख — mention; reference

परिहरि — having abandoned

तोरिए — yours

पाछिलि — of the past; belonging to what came before

सनि — like; resembling

अछलिहुँ — I was

छाजत — will shine; will appear splendid

घोसिनी — a cowherd woman

बथु — an object; a thing

अरतल — attached; enamoured

रव — noise; commotion

राहि — Rādhā

तापिनि — a flame

बयने — speech; utterance

धरनि — the earth

इथि — of this

जोतिअ — astrology

मुरछइ — fainting; loss of consciousness

आइति — subjection; dependence

महते — from the elephant-driver

नव — bends down

एहो — this too; this

बटमारी — robbery on the road

तुलाएल — increased; augmented

पसार — a shop

पढ़ओंक — the first sale of the day

कुंगयाँ — an ignorant rustic (from a bad village)

आजि — I shall apply it; I shall put it on

आग — a limb; a part of the body

गोए — having concealed

इन्दुमुखी — moon-faced

तहु — from that too

परिहरिहह — I shall abandon it

सेचान — a hawk; a falcon

भामि-भामि — wandering about

विरडा — a cat

सुरते — amorous play

काहिअ अवधारि — speaks with firm conviction

अन्तर नारी — a woman's heart

रोखए — anger

गंजए — humiliation; reproach

रंजए — gladdens; pleases

साह — he; that person

तरासे — out of fear

परुष — hard; harsh

सोस — dry; desiccated

चेतन — capable

आथि — is

दूषलि — sorrow; distress

निमाल — the remnants of a ritual offering

अंसुक — clothing

वाँलभु — beloved

नठल — destroyed

परबोध — awakening; enlightenment

पांगुर — a toe

खिति — the earth

गीभ — the neck

अनुसए — repentance; remorse

अनुरञ्जब — I shall be able to manage it

विरमाने — a resting-place

एहो पय — on that too

जार — having burned

नखत — a star; a constellation

जुगुतिहि — by reasoning

दोहाए — an oath

रङ्ग — affection; love

गरुअ — heavier; more serious

पिसुन — a talebearer; slanderer

अरुझओहल — entangled

कञोनकँ — upon whom?

बारि — having saved; protecting

फुलधालि — having put on flowers

कैतवे — through deceit

अह — day

सपजत — सपरज

वथु — an object; a thing

मोन्ति — a pearl

धम्मिल — a tress of hair

धोएल — established; set in place

अङ्गिरि — to accept; to acknowledge

पुनिमाँ — the full moon

विभिनावए — can separate

आनन — face

तिमिशरि — an enemy of darkness

चालक — one who impels; an inspirer

बम — vomiting; spewing forth

भीभ — भआवोन

ओल — the end

कवल — a morsel

सरूप — truth

निसिअर — a creature of the night

भुअङ्गम — a snake

उजोर — light

झाप — to sink; to submerge

मेंदुर — dense; thick

मुदिर — a cloud

पाउस — the rainy season

निसा — night

निबिल — dense; impenetrable

निचोल — a sari

जामिक — a watchman; guard

थैरेज — steadiness; stability

थोइआ — having placed; having set down

रजनि — night

सिरहि — in beauty; in splendour

असिलाइ — became faded

वालँभू — husband; lord

मुसए — in order to steal

छैलरि — of a deceiver

अरथित — through supplication

जड़ाइअ — make it cool

विरत रस — whose taste has disappeared

अचेतन — a fool

कके — why?

लाघव — disrespect

चिटि-गुड़े — an ant and jaggery

चुपड़लि — interest (on a loan)

लओले लोथे — even after making an excuse

झाल — dry; withered

दरनि — a crack; fissure

असेखि — without remainder; entire

असहति — intolerance

तत्न — a system; a tantra

भाझहि — in the middle

खीनी — weakened; emaciated

झपावह — may be covering

परिरम्भि — having embraced

फुजलि — opened

घोषसि — a proclamation; a declaration

नखर — a fingernail

पाँच पाँच गुन दस गुन चौगुन आठ दुगुन — five times five, times ten, times four, times eight, times two: 5 × 5 × 10 × 4 × 8 × 2 = 16,000

नखर — a fingernail

छाँद — beauty; splendour

हिया — the heart

सदय — helpful; a helper

कानुक — of Kānha (Krishna)

निरसाओल — made devoid of flavour or relish

सखिता — attested; made a witness

करवाल — a sword

काँढ़ — comes out; emerges

कार — black

उजागरि — white; bright

परिपन्तिहि — the adversary; the opponent

पयगन्ड — mature; grown-up

मधुमखिका — a honeybee

उधारल — rescued; delivered

लागर — endowed with; equipped

पुरहर — the auspicious ceremonial pitcher used at weddings

मन्दाकिनी — water of the Ganges

केसु — the palāśa or flame-of-the-forest flower

विथुरलहु — spread out

भिति — a wall

पौञनाल — the stalk of a lotus

रात — red

ऐपन — aripan, a ceremonial floor design

हथोदक — water poured upon or offered by the hands

विधु — weariness from travelling

कनए-केआ — champak and banana; kanak and kadalī

जैतुक — dowry

डिठि — sight; vision

तुलइलिहुँ — quickly

अनुबन्ध — attaching; joining

बोल छ़ड़ — one who speaks falsely

मज्जि — having bathed; having immersed oneself

विथरओ — may spread; may extend

पाड़रि — rose; pāṭalī

भोपति — for me

वाउलि — mad; crazed

विधुन्तुद — Rāhu

सेरी — a person seeking refuge

परभृतक — the cuckoo

मतँ — a mantra; incantation

कि रहसि बोरि — are you speaking in jest?

बालहि तोरि — your beloved woman

भर बादर — filled with clouds

झम्पि — forcefully, again and again

सघने खर — fierce and dense harshness

डाहुकि — loudly

थेघा — having propped up; supported

पख — side; faction

पिआजे — the beloved

पङ्का — an application; a paste

तथुहु — in that too

दर — unprecedented; extraordinary

अपद — without cause

साती — intense anguish

अवथाजे — condition; state

पसाइल — spread out

रासे — anger

बालभु — the beloved

अएत — subject to; under another's control

सपूने — complete; entire

दिगन्तर — in a distant country

अरुझाए — entangled

आधिन — subordinate; dependent

पललि — happened; occurred

खेजोब — forgiveness

जल आजुरि — a libation of water

सुसेरा — a beautiful refuge

गोए — having concealed

सम्भ्रम — sudden; unexpected

कराडहार — a boatman's handhold or support used while crossing the Yamuna

लहु-लहु आखरे — short, short syllables

तामरस — a lotus

घनसार — camphor

वेपथु — trembling; a tremor

मसृण — smooth

सुदति — a woman with beautiful teeth

सुति — hearing; sacred revelation (śruti)

जति — as much as; however many

घमिअ — is blown upon

आनइति — being under another's control

दीब — an oath

बड़इ — very much; many

देव देयासिनि — a woman who performs ritual blowing and exorcism

जटिला — a harsh-tempered woman

फुकरि — screaming; crying out

बहुरि — a daughter-in-law

अङ्गा — a mark; a sign

बेसर — a nose ornament

यन्त्रिया — a player of the vīṇā

यन्त्र — the vīṇā

फोटा — a mark on the forehead; a ṭīkā

समत — agreed; accepted

मौलि — on the head

मुसरँ — a pestle

जेमाओव — food; a meal

नवइते — descending

पडिचाँ — a mat

माड़व — a wedding pavilion

उगारल — to surround and seize

आँजल — collyrium; eye-black

डाढ़ल — burned; scorched

गौह — a hollow; cave

बिलुविअ — may be distributed

मउल — a crown

डाढ़ति — will burn

श्मश्रु — the beard (facial hair, not a food item)

अधँगँ — half of the body; one's other half

गरुअ — more; greater

अभरन — clothing to be worn

बड़ाव — praise

तौ — nevertheless

निसाकर — the moon

सरिस — like; similar

तांतल — heated; burning hot

सैकत — sand

हब — will be

निधुवन — sexual intercourse

आरा — another; other

कहाओसि — is called; is made to say

राजमराल — a royal swan

3. Vocabulary of Rasamaya Poet Chatur Chaturbhuj

Rasamaya poet Chatur Chaturbhuj was a poet of Vidyapati's period. Only seventeen of his poems survive, yet those seventeen compositions are sufficient to make his literary fame imperishable.

विहि — the creator; the ordainer of fate

सजानि — a young woman

तनु — age; the body

आँतर — the inside; within

गोए — to conceal; to hide

वेकत — expressed; manifest

गेहा — a place

परि — in the manner of; by way of

विरहानल — the fire of separation

काँती — radiance; beauty

धमित — heated; made to glow

निरूपए — examines; observes

परिहर — neglect; disregard

अचिरहिँ — in a short while

वामे — adverse; contrary

निअ — one's own

मलयज — sandalwood

सयानि — a heroine consumed by the sorrow of separation

धनि — the fortunate or beloved heroine

हेरसि — looks at; gazes

हरषि — having rejoiced

परिहरि — having removed; having erased

नखत — the stars

मधुरि-दल — both lips

मनसिज — Kāmadeva, the god of love

अवनत — bending down

हुतासन — flame; fire

4. Vocabulary of Badrinath Jha

मिलिन — a honeybee; a bumblebee

रसाल — a mango tree; sugarcane

अतन्द्र — alert; vigilant; wakeful

खद्योत — a firefly

दुर्वार — difficult; hard to withstand

यति — a restriction; as many times as

अचलसेतु — the inscription of unseen fate

विपिन — a forest

तरणि — a boat

अवाम — the right-hand side

गरुड़केतु — Viṣṇu

बौड़ि — deranged; frenzied

तुषार — cool; cold

ब्रह्मर्षिसुत — Kaśyapa, the son of a Brahmin sage

वारुणी — the western direction

कश्यप — a sage; also, a drinker of liquor

प्रतीची — the western direction

कुलाय — a nest

साँझ — samādhi, or a conjunction/assemblage

जीव-अभिदान — a name given to a living being

कमान — a bow

विधु — the moon

हय — a little; somewhat

नमि — obeisance; salutation

नीराजन — the ārati performed in the morning

मानर — the mṛdaṅga drum

काहल — a particular musical instrument

चतुविध — the four kinds: bodily, verbal, psychophysical, and costuming/stage appearance

उडुगण — the multitude of stars

दैवज्ञ — an astrologer

पाटल — red

पाटल — spread out; pervaded

अविद्या — ignorance

अधित्यका — land on the top of a mountain

कुशण्डिका — ritual cleansing of the sacrificial altar and related acts

मेधा — a retentive, discerning intellect

सम्भार — materials; requisites

कज्जल — black; collyrium

भूयसी — a particular kind of ritual gift to a priest

दीठि — sight; vision

नृपदार — a queen

परिचार — attendance; care; service

फुलहरा — the koṛhilā shrub

राजीव — a lotus

मुदवारि — tears of joy

तृष — thirst; craving

पाञ्चजन्य — a conch shell

जगत्ताताक — Viṣṇu, father of the world

प्रत्यभिवादन — a return salutation

जूटिका — a tuft of hair on the crown

गोए — concealed; hidden

गुरु-सन्तोख — the honorarium or offering given to a teacher

अवसित — completed; finished

श्रुतिवेध — ear piercing

प्रभाक — brilliance; talent

गुरु-शुद्धि — the ritual purification of Bṛhaspati (Jupiter)

औड़ि — a special form of insistence

शिविका — a palanquin

पूर्वाङ्ग-कृत्य — preliminary rites, including worship of the Mother Goddesses

अदम्भ — without pretence; guileless

वैजयन्त — Indra's palace

कौशेय वसन — silk clothing

भक्ष्य चतुर्विध — four classes of food: what is eaten or chewed, such as rice; what is consumed, such as puffed grain; what is licked, such as chutney; and what is sucked, such as mango

नीवार — the grain called oiri

अनुताप — remorse; repentance

बद्धकर — miserly; tight-fisted

विमति — detachment; disinclination

वैमत्य — difference of opinion

प्रसाद — gladness; satisfaction

अनुरोध — preference; liking

आर्य — excellent; noble

जाचल — tested; examined

सुभगप्रक्रिय — good repute; good conduct

अचलेश — a ruler of the earth

बिहान — daybreak; dawn

पट्टपटसार — fine silk cloth

विभूतिवत — splendour; prosperity

एकतान — one-pointed concentration

वनी — one who has entered the forest-dweller stage of life

और्ध्वदैहिक — śrāddha rites performed for the deceased for their welfare in the next world

भोज-ओज — miserliness

चञ्चरीक — a bumblebee

सोहल — adorned; made beautiful

छान — a stain; blemish

अदक्षिण — adverse; unfavourable

इन्दीवर — a blue lotus

कीर — a parrot

अकानल — heard

पोषक-द्वेषक — an enemy of the crow that nourishes or feeds

श्मश्रु — beard and moustache

शैवाल-लतिका — a creeper of the semar tree

कुण्डलित — coiled; wrapped around

कर्णिकार — the kanail flower

ग्रीवा — the neck

इन्द्रायुध — Indra's thunderbolt

तमाल-साल — the sākhū tree

शम्पा — a flash of lightning

सहकार — a mango

वकुलमुकुल — the bud of the bhālsarī (bakul) tree

पखान — stone

दमनक — the donā flower

अंसयुगल — both shoulders

अश्मसार — iron

मणिबन्ध — the wrist

अबलासव — opposition; resistance

दुहिण — Brahmā

जम्भरिपु — Indra, the foe of Jambha

ऊरु — the thigh

आरत — opposition

नीरज — not produced in water; free from dust; opposition

इलातनय — Purūravas, the son of Ilā

सुरवैद्ययुगल — the twin Aśvin physicians of the gods

क्षितिहरिहम — the lord of the earth

परपुष्ट — a cuckoo; in an alternative sense, a well-nourished courtesan

मधुप — a bee; a drinker of liquor

आतङ्करङ्क — fearless

काव्यक — pertaining to a parrot

मधुभरि — until springtime

सुरभिमग — the road or path of Kāmadhenu, the wish-fulfilling cow

अनीति — free from excessive rain and the like

शिक्षालोक — the light of learning

तास्रव — a loud sound

जनपद — one's own country or region

साभिनिवेश — with insistence; earnestly

धारणा-ध्याण — concentration (dhāraṇā) and meditation (dhyāna), the sixth and seventh limbs of eightfold yoga

प्रकृति — nature; disposition; subjects or people

पीयूष-यूष — the essence of nectar

मार्तण्ड — the sun

सत्वक — the quality of sattva

सौम्य — the planet Mercury

वाक्पति — Bṛhaspati (Jupiter)

रवि-कल्प — resembling the sun

याचना-परायण — one devoted to begging; a supplicant

अभियोगी — one who makes an accusation

कैरवामोद — the fragrance of a night-blooming water lily; the enemy's delight

अनुदार — subordinate to a woman

पुत्रेष्टिक — the rite or sacrifice for obtaining a son

एकावली — a necklace of pearls

मत्सरिता — envy of another's good fortune

लालनसुहिता — satisfied or favourably disposed through affection

परिणाह — growth; enlargement

प्रमत्त — heedless; intoxicated; mad

बालवशामे — a young female elephant

आविल — muddy; turbid

अर्धचन्द्र — a half-moon; also a slap delivered with the curved hand

शिखिकलाप — a peacock's tail feathers; also, something uneven or irregular

बलाहक — a cloud

सरणी — the sky

जड़भाव — coldness; the condition of being water

मेचक — dark blue

द्विरद — an elephant

धम्मिल्ल — a knot or coil of hair

विलक्ष — ashamed; embarrassed

पथिक-चक्र — the circle or group of cakravāka birds

काली — black in colour

तारा — the pupil of the eye

काली — Kālī, the first of the Mahāvidyās

तारा — Tārā, the second Mahāvidyā

चतुश्रुति — the fourfold śruti or Vedic knowledge; Brahmā as its reciter

श्रुति — the ear; hearing

विश्रुति — accomplishment; success

छीजक — the act of being wasted or destroyed

कलकण्ठी — a cuckoo

तप्त-तपनीय — gold

चिवुक — the chin

परिस्फुर — restless; flickering

लेखा — reckoning; calculation

जूझल — fought

महायति — exceedingly vast

आहित — placed; established

स्तूप — a heap of earth

लिकुचक — belonging to the baṛhar fruit/tree

श्रीफल-मद — the pride of the bilva fruit

गर्त — a pit; hole

कुलाल — a potter

नाभिभव — Brahmā, born from the navel

शारदा — the invisible Sarasvatī river (Śāradā in an unseen form)

त्रिदिवस सारिणी — the Ganges

वली — the three folds on the abdomen

बली — strong; powerful

पाटच्चर — a thief

केहरि — a lion

नितम्बक — of the middle section of a mountain

विधिओजक — of splendour or majesty

कृष-नीच — growing progressively thinner towards the lower end (said of the leg)

वेत्र-दण्ड — a golden ceremonial staff of authority

हंसक — an anklet

दश-शशधर — the ten moon-like fingernails

लाजें बीतल — contracted or withdrawn through shame

अनृत-दूषण-कृपाणी — a knife that destroys false accusations or blemishes

कथाऽवशेष — what remains to be said

हर्ष-नृत्त — dancing in joy; the expressive movement of the limbs

सभीक — frightened; afraid

सागर-परिपन्थी — one who vies with the ocean

सम्पुटित — folded; contracted

विगेय — blameworthy

विजीहीर्षा — the desire to stroll or take pleasure

दलतर — beneath the leaves

अतिसुकवि-ऊह — beyond even a fine poet's conjecture or reasoning

कुवलय-रम्भा-समान — a Rambhā-like beauty of the entire earth

देवाङ्गनीय — pertaining to a celestial damsel

रास — a circular dance

श्यामा — the priyangu plant

व्यामोहक — bewitching; entrancing

काल — Yama, the god of death

कृतयुग — the Satya Yuga

रण-एकतान — one who is invariably victorious in battle

नृपति-पताकिनीक — of the king's army

विकटप्रतीक — of fearsome appearance

पुण्डरीक — a tiger

दिनेन्दु-दीन — pale like the moon in daylight

सर्वसहाक — of the earth, which bears all things

लीन — subsumed in cosmic dissolution

विलीन — dissolved; vanished

गोए — kept; retained

तदनुसार — subsequently; afterwards

विदग्धताक — of refinement and aesthetic sensibility

गरुअ — large; great

भूरमाक — of Lakṣmī of the earth

शर्म — happiness; comfort

दलितपांशु — sinless; innocent

भवितव्यवश्य — subject to destiny

अननुरूप — unsuited; adverse

प्रणिधानलीन — absorbed in meditation

द्विजदत्त — given by an accomplished Brahmin

दत्त-प्रदत्त — given by Dattātreya

उदेष — search; inquiry

स्वरति — love for oneself or one's own subject

धैर्य-कदर्य — impatient; lacking fortitude

चरमदशाक — of the final stage, death

अवगाह — agitation; stirring

ओज — strength; brilliance

यशस्य — productive of renown

अलेश — guileless; without deceit

विजिगीषा — the desire for victory

पुटपाक — a preparation cooked after enclosing the substance between two earthen vessels

हयग्रीव — the demon Hayagrīva, slain by Viṣṇu

अनन्त — endless; without end

व्यपाय — complete; fulfilled

भङ्ग — defeat

सङ्गर — battle; war

तनु — soft; delicate

आश्रित-दुर्ग — a worshipper of Durgā

दुर्ग — Durgā, difficult of approach and served by demons

सर्वसहा — the earth that bears everything; endurance; the all-enduring earth

मनु — a mantra

शिव — auspicious; benevolent

कूर्च — the syllable hrīṃ (ह्रीं)

शिखिजाया — the exclamation svāhā

आखर — the syllables: "ह्रीं गौरि! रुद्रदयिते! योगेश्वरी। हूँ फट स्वाहा"

अन्वर्थाख्य — one whose name accords with the meaning; aptly named

सिद्धि — attainment; accomplishment; perfection

ब्राह्मण — the Brahmin feast in the five-part puraścaraṇa rite: tarpaṇa, mārjana, feeding Brahmins, and nṛsoma

वैन्य — King Pṛthu

फलक — a shield

शिशुमार — a river dolphin (soṃs)

धन-शाद — mud; mire

क्षेपणी — the implement called karuār

पटमण्डप — a tent

यादस्स्वन — the sounds of aquatic creatures

पूत — pure; sanctified

द्विरदकाँ — to the elephant

दानजल — the rut fluid of an elephant

मन-अवसाद — grief; sorrow

भव्य — auspicious; beautiful

आयुधराजि — flashing lightning

चैत्य — a well-known or prominent building

दुर्ग — a fortress

सुचतुष्पश — a four-way crossroads

अहम्पूविका — a competitive rush to be first: “I first! No, I first!”

पवि — Indra's thunderbolt

अर्थ — purpose; intention

प्रभूत — abundant; plentiful

लाघव — swiftness; speed

दनुज-तनुज — born in the body

अर्भ — a child

सुरसरणी — the sky

शारिका — a myna bird

मेकल — the mountain from which the Narmadā river rises

परिपाटी — tradition; established practice

उत्कोच — a bribe

वितान — extension; expanse

प्रकोष्ठ — the wrist

अङ्गुरीय — a ring

केतन — a banner; flag

निर्मम — without possessive attachment

उदिखर — risen; emerged

दीधिति — moonlight

दक्षिण — equally attached to several persons; also, right-hand or southern

मत्सरी — envious; jealous

विनिपातोन्मुख — inclined towards downfall

मधु-सञ्जँ — by name

नृपदारक — the king's daughter

प्रमोद-निबन्धन — a cause of delight

वन्दी — a prisoner

पुरुषार्थ चतुष्टय — the four aims of human life: dharma, wealth, desire and liberation

दीधिति-माली — the sun

नरनाथ — the retinue

औरस-सुत — a son born to a man by his lawful wife

चक्रधर — Nārāyaṇa, the bearer of the discus

ईषत्कर — easy to accomplish

कुलिशायुधसँ — from Indra, the wielder of the thunderbolt

प्रमा-सालित — enlarged or strengthened by true knowledge

उक्ति-प्रगल्भ — mature and confident in speech

शमन — Yama, the god of death

विधेय — a duty; something that ought to be done

दुर्विपाक — an evil consequence

सङ्कल्प-कल्पना — the fashioning of mental acts through intention and imagination

स्तम्भित — immobilised; made inert

सकल-करण-परिवारक — of the whole group of sense organs

भव-झरिणी — the river of worldly existence

शशिकान्त — the moonstone gem

रजनिकर — through beauty or radiance

निष्कपट — with sincere liking and affection

द्रुत — swift; rapid

विद्रुत — melted

मानसिक — of mental transgression or misconduct

उन्मिषित — expanded; increased

प्रकृतिस्थ — conscious; in possession of awareness

कालासुर — the demon Kālaketu

अमान — immeasurable; limitless

अमानव — supernatural; beyond the human

कुरङ्गित — leaping like a deer

विक्रम — an unusual order, or one in which the sequence has been disrupted

पञ्चानन — a lion

आरभटी — ostentatious or flamboyant conduct

दुरभिसन्धि — a malicious design

कान्दिशीक — one who flees in fear

अनाथ — a widow

धृष्ट — mature; grown

निकृष्ट — base; inferior; small

उपरोधन — fortitude

अनारम्भ — not beginning; refraining from commencement

भानुमान — the sun

कृकलाश — a chameleon

सन्नाह — preparation for battle

मधु-मधुरिमार्ह — as sweet as grapes; of an exceedingly sweet flavour

सर्वज्ञम्मन्य — one who considers oneself omniscient

वीरमानी — one who considers oneself a hero

नृशंस — cruel; ruthless in speech

अपलापपरा — intent on kicking

प्राथमिक — for the first time; initial

प्रकार — of a wall

अज — a he-goat

कुरङ्ग — a deer

गवय — the nilgai, an antelope resembling cattle

शार्दूल — a tiger

साम्हर — an animal resembling a deer

भूतनाथ — Mahādeva (Śiva)

प्रमथराजि — a multitude of gaṇas or attendants

शृङ्गी — having horns

जटी — wearing matted locks

वारणरद — having tusks like those of an elephant

पुच्छी — a tail

कृत्तिपटी — wearing a tiger skin

चत्वर — a rock; stone slab

भीरुभीमा — terrifying to the timid

पटल — covered over

जन्य — war; battle

राजन्य — a Kṣatriya

भिन्दिपाल — a weapon that hurls a pellet like the ḍhelmāsu implement

तोमर — a weapon resembling a churning rod

कृपाण — a sword

परशु — an axe

असि धेनु — a short sword or knife

भुशुण्डी — a fire-based weapon

परिध — a hammer

दनुजभुवन — the netherworld

जलद-छाया — the shade of clouds; similarly, something unstable or transient

मृत्युशक्ति-उत्क्रान्तिदा — Death possesses a power called utkrāntidā, by which it causes the departure of a living being

वृन्दारक-वृन्दक — a company of gods

निजचमू — one's own army

पताल — the seven nether regions: Atala, Vitala, Sutala, Talātala, Mahātala, Rasātala and Pātāla

सन्देश — a message; communication

त्रिदिवहुँ — even in heaven

प्रत्यूष — early morning; dawn

दानव-भोगिनी — an ordinary woman attached to a king

अभ्यास — yogic practice

क्लेश — the five afflictions: ignorance, egoity, attachment, aversion and clinging to life

जनि — birth

भोगभू — the place or ground of enjoyment

भुजगभुवन — the netherworld of serpents

नाक — heaven

सहस्रार — the thousand-petalled lotus-shaped energy centre at the top of the head

निर्मन्तु — innocent; guiltless

फेरि — turned around; rotated

फेरि — again

अन्तराय — an obstacle; impediment

याचकपटलीकल्प — like a crowd of supplicants

रहस्योद्भेदसँ — through the disclosure of a secret love

लोकपति — a king; ruler

मध्यमलोक — the middle world; the mortal realm

अधोभुवन — the lower world; the netherworld

नररिक्त — devoid of human beings

तूर्ण — rapidly; quickly

उद्देश — utterance; pronunciation

उपेन्द्र — Lord Vāmana, an incarnation of Viṣṇu

कन्याक — of Devayānī, the daughter of Śukra

अर्थना — entreaty; request

सपरिकर — with family and attendants

पुरुषसूक्त — the Puruṣasūkta, the sixteen Vedic stanzas beginning “ओँ सहस्रशीर्षा”

दुइ — two, identified as Nārāyaṇa and Turvasu (in the description of one's two fathers)

प्रतिग्रह — acceptance of a gift

लाजहोम — the ritual offering known as lājahoma

लाजहोममे — the offering of parched grain in the lājahoma ritual

प्रणयकोपक — anger or sulking arising from love

अपसारण-गति — a means of removal

परमाणु — one-sixth of a mote visible in a sunbeam

द्वयणुक — two atoms

पूगीफल — a betel nut

व्यङ्गयवचन — a statement conveying an implied or sarcastic meaning

दिवसचतुष्टय — four days

गानचातुरी-विवरण — the publication of an account of skill in singing

कान-सुधारस-वितरण — the gift or distribution of nectar-like sweetness to the ears

चारिमशुचि — adorned with beauty

पाँकल — caught in the mud

निमीलित — closed; contracted

कीलित — bound; afflicted

मदन-रुजा — the disease or suffering of love

निर्वापि — to pacify; to bring peace

समाजित — worshipped; honoured

उद्भेद — development; emergence

चलदल — a peepal tree

मन्मथ-घर्षण — boldness or audacity in the friction of love

कल्पकल्प — resembling a cosmic aeon (kalpa)

आशा — a direction; point of the compass

विदग्ध — distressed; also, a connoisseur of love and art

सुरतवितान — the arts and activities of erotic play

वितानल — expanded; made extensive

संभोग — the first aspect of śṛṅgāra, erotic dalliance or union

विप्रलम्भ — the later aspect of śṛṅgāra, separation from the beloved

अवसित — finished; concluded

विधुर — bereft; separated (as in "dīpaka-vidhu-vidhura")

अनवम — faultless; without blemish

विरस — indifferent; detached; disinclined

पञ्चयज्ञ — the five daily sacrifices: Brahmayajña (studying and teaching the Vedas), Pitṛyajña (offerings to the ancestors and daily śrāddha), Devayajña (fire oblation), Bhūtayajña (the offering to living beings known as vaiśvadeva-bali), and Nṛpajña (hospitality to guests)

पर्व — a festival

आन्तरिक — the inner faculty or mind (antaḥkaraṇa)

मञ्जूषा — a box; chest

भूमिनेता — ruler of the earth

जरती — an elderly woman

वैजयन्त — of Indra's palace adorned by Indrāṇī

पति-परिचार — service to one's husband or lord

मन्त्र — reflection; deliberation

कान्त — beloved; dear

श्लाघापरायण — eager to praise

धव — an attack; charge

मधुपा — a woman who drinks liquor

भूरि — much; abundant

सर्वसहासमेत — together with the all-enduring earth, which bears every sorrow

कासर — a water buffalo

हिण्डोर — a swing

शैलूष-कुहना — the illusion or trickery of an actor

Alongside these, read Harimohan Jha, Yatri, Dhumketu, Saketanand, Ramabhadra, Dhirendra, Kapari, Malangia, Nachiketa, Kulanand Mishra, Rajkamal, Rajmohan Jha, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Premshankar Singh, Ramanand Jha "Raman", Mohan Bharadwaj, Ramanath Jha, Jivakant, Prabhas Kumar Choudhary, Lily Ray, Ilarani Singh and Ramlochan Thakur. Study thoroughly Dinbandhu Jha's Dhaturup and Ramanath Jha's Mithilabhasha Prakash, as well as the textbooks for Classes Nine and Ten in India and Nepal. If you can also read and write Mithilakshar fluently, you will be able to connect yourself to the Maithili literary tradition and move beyond mediocrity. Read Maithili periodicals and translated literature too. You should also study the history of Videha, Mithila, Tirabhukti and Tirhut, and the works and lives of eminent men and women. Once this preparation is complete, the literature that emerges from your pen will have a distinctive flavour.

29. Maithili, Surjapuri and Rajbanshi

Abstract

Maithili–Surjapuri–Rajbanshi. Babu may never have recognised the political ground on which he stood while he remained in the party to which Ram had once introduced him. Although he was described as an influential leader in the party, he was never presented as a leader of the backward classes. Yet Babu, more adept at political manoeuvring than at establishing a political base, rose so considerably in the eyes of the opposition immediately after his expulsion that it installed him in the state's seat of leadership reserved for the backward classes. In Surjapuri (in the Kishanganj region and elsewhere on the Indian side), this would be written or spoken as follows: "बाबूक अपना यहार राजनीतिक जमीनेर अहसास उस दलात रहले नी होबे।"

Keywords: Surjapuri · Rajbanshi · critical theory · Maithili

Maithili–Surjapuri–Rajbanshi

Maithili

Babu may never have become conscious of the political ground on which he stood, even while belonging to the party with which Ram had once brought him into association. Though called an influential leader within that party, Babu was never presented as a leader of the backward classes. But Babu, more skilful at political combinations than at establishing a political base, came so prominently into the opposition party's view as soon as he was expelled that it installed him, on its own behalf, in the position of leader of the backward classes in the state.

In Surjapuri (spoken in Kishanganj and adjoining areas on the Indian side), it would be written or spoken thus:

"बाबूक अपना यहार राजनीतिक जमीनेर अहसास उस दलात रहले नी होबे। जहाक कोईखुन वहाय रामेर संगे सीचे छीले। दलात एक कद्दावर नेता कहा जनवार बाबू कोईखुन पिछ्वाड़ नेतार लखा पेश नी करील। लेकिन राजनीतिक से बेसी जोड़तोड़ोत माहिर बाबू दलार से निकलाते ही प्रतिपक्षी-दलाड़ नजरोत हिरंगदी चढ़ील कि वहाय पाटी अपनार बीती से प्रदेशोत पिछड़ार नेतार गद्दीत विरजमान करील।"

English rendering of the Surjapuri passage: Babu may not have realised his own political position while he remained in the party where he had once been with Ram. Although he was spoken of as a formidable leader there, Babu was never presented as a backward-class leader. Yet Babu, more accomplished in political manoeuvring than in political groundwork, came so prominently to the attention of the opposition immediately after leaving the party that it appointed him, on its own behalf, to the seat of backward-class leadership in the state.

In Rajbanshi (Surjapuri is called the Rajbanshi language on the Nepal side,

in Jhapa, Sarnamati, Chakamaki, Mechi, Tadhnduwa and other localities; there is only a slight difference between Rajbanshi and Surjapuri), it would be written or spoken as follows:

"बाबूर अपनार इर राजनीतिक जमीनेर ऐहसास उखान दल त रहते हुए भी नी होल, जइर कोधोय उम्हा रामेर संगे छिले। दलात एक कद्दावर नेता कहवार बाबूर कोधोय पिछड़ा नेतार लाखा पेश नी करे। माने राजनीतिक जमीनत भेल्ला जोड़तोड़ माहिर बाबू दल से निकलाले ही प्रतिपक्षी-दलार नजर एनंतिंज चढ़िल कि अम्हा पार्टीत अपनार तरफ से प्रदेशत छट जातिर नेतारक गद्धी पर बठाइ दिल।"

English rendering of the Rajbanshi passage: Babu did not realise his own political standing even while remaining in that party, with which Ram had once been associated with him. Although he was called a strong leader in the party, Babu was never put forward as a backward-class leader. Rather than cultivating a political base, Babu was skilled at making political combinations; once he left the party, he rose so high in the eyes of the opposition that the party installed him, on its own behalf, in the state's leadership seat for the smaller or backward castes.

Surjapuri: In India, this language is spoken village by village by members of the Rajbanshi (Mahadalit) caste in Kishanganj, Purnia and other parts of Bihar. Among Muslims in Kishanganj, the landowning caste is called Khotta and the service caste Kulhiya. The Kulhiya community also speaks Surjapuri. Rajbanshis and members of other castes living around the Kulhiyas speak Surjapuri. It is a mixture of Maithili and Bengali. Some people also call the language of the Bahe Bengalis of Cooch Behar in Bengal and the Rajbanshi language of Nepal Surjapuri. Others believe that Surjapuri emerged from a mixture of the language of people from Bangladesh with the regional language. In a single village of Purnia or Kishanganj, Kulhiyas and Rajbanshis speak Surjapuri, Santhals speak Santhali, Banjaras speak the Banjara language, while all the remaining people speak Maithili. If these regions are incorporated into a Mithila state, their inhabitants will have to be guaranteed the development of their respective languages. Has the thinking of the campaigners for a Mithila state reached that far?

30. Folk Elements in Literature: Ballads, Dance and Drama

Abstract

The bronze figurine recovered from the civilisation of Mohenjo-daro suggests a dance posture resembling the thāṭ pose of contemporary Kathak: the right arm making an angle of forty-five degrees, the left hand resting on the left hip, and the left leg slightly bent. The Śāṅkhāyana Brāhmaṇa of the Rigveda describes the combined use of song, instrumental music and dance; the Aitareya Brāhmaṇa counts all three among the divine arts. In Rigveda 10.76.6, the golden radiance of Uṣas reminds the poet of an adorned seer.

Keywords: folk elements in literature · ballads · dance · drama · critical theory · Maithili

Historical Accounts of Folk Ballads, Dance and Music

The bronze figurine recovered from the civilisation of Mohenjo-daro suggests a dance posture resembling the *thāṭ* pose of contemporary Kathak: the right arm making an angle of forty-five degrees, the left hand resting on the left hip, and the left leg slightly bent. The Śāṅkhāyana Brāhmaṇa of the Rigveda describes the combined use of song, instrumental music and dance; the Aitareya Brāhmaṇa includes all three among divine arts. In Rigveda 10.76.6, the golden radiance of Uṣas reminds the poet of an adorned seer. The Rigveda also mentions folk dancing (*prāñco agāma nṛtaye*). The *Mahāvrata* Soma sacrifice describes a group dance by three to six female servants. Śāṅkhāyana 1.11.5 describes four to eight married women being given liquor at a wedding and encouraged to dance four times. Vedic literature mentions the wife singing during wedding rituals. At the *sīmantonnayana* ceremony, the husband requests a vīṇā player to perform a song accompanied by instruments in honour of the god Soma. The Atharvaveda associates the dance of the deity Vasā with *ṛc*, *sāman* and *gāthā*, and describes Gandharvas participating in this dance, which involved drinking Soma. Atharvaveda 12.1.41 describes the combined sound of song, instruments and dance. During the Vedic period, alongside Sāman music, there were also secular forms of ballad-music called *gāthā* and *nārāśaṃsī*.

Elements of the folk ballad: because its language is transmitted orally, its form remains dynamic. Dating it likewise depends on conjecture.

Ballads are performed at fairs, weekly markets, in the homes of prominent people and in public places. Beyond members of the caste to which the folk deity belongs, listeners from other castes are also present.

The creator and the audience have a direct relationship. The element of listening gives rise to spontaneous embellishment of the narrative. Yet many literary features—such as cantos, regulated metre, dramatic junctures and indications of the subject—are absent. The organisation of the material is not tightly structured. There are scattered references to abuse and liquor-drinking.

The place occupied by thieves in rural society and their depiction, references to local gods and goddesses, and expressions of caste identity all occur. The ballad-singer is an improvising poet: working from a framework, the singer alters the performance at will. An invocation of God at the beginning and occasional requests for divine forgiveness during the performance serve to steady the singer's capacity to perform.

In performances lasting more than an hour, smoking the hookah or *chilam*, drinking liquor and describing the surroundings appear within the singing. The *Lorik Manuār* ballad is performed before an audience, whereas the story of Salhes is performed before the deity who is worshipped.

Divine power assists the hero in battle.

The hero, too, uses abusive language.

Names and other elements are borrowed from epic characters and incidents, such as gambling in the Mahabharata.

Conclusion: literary forms are of two kinds, *lokadharmī* and *nāṭyadharmī*. The former is associated with the vernacular and rural, the latter with classical modes of expression. Rural here signifies a disregard for artificiality; through ignorance, however, some take *lokadharmī* to mean a play staged in a village. In *lokadharmī* performance, the natural enactment of character and ordinary human action predominate; physical expression is simple, and the number of characters, women as well as men, is very large. In *nāṭyadharmī* performance, speech may occur inwardly, through gesture, or as a voice from the sky; dance is incorporated; the language is distinctive; music is organised through rāgas; and divine characters appear alongside ordinary ones. Inanimate objects and animals may begin to speak, a performer may play double or triple roles, and the emotional intensity of happiness or sorrow is heightened by music.

Vedic narratives, the Jātaka tales, Aesop's Fables, the Panchatantra and the Hitopadeśa have all existed alongside folk ballads. Everywhere, ballads have persisted beside the stories of the elite.

31. Hindi, Maithili and Literary Vocabulary

Abstract

Hindi has expanded its geographical reach without correspondingly expanding its vocabulary, and there is therefore no question of fearing Hindi. Hindi imperialism has taken the place of English imperialism, and the debate about its propensity to bring down smaller languages cannot be stopped on Hindi Day. All the indigenous languages of Latin and South America disappeared, and Spanish and Portuguese took their place.

Keywords: Hindi · literary vocabulary · critical theory · Maithili

Hindi has expanded its geographical reach without expanding its vocabulary to the same degree; there is therefore no question of fearing Hindi. Hindi imperialism has taken the place of English imperialism, and on Hindi Day one cannot suppress debate over its tendency to bring down the smaller languages. All the indigenous languages of Latin and South America disappeared, and Spanish and Portuguese took their place. Spain destroyed Aztec civilisation and erased its distinguishing signs; subsequently, as an act of contrition, Mexico named the stadium built to host the football World Cup the Aztec Stadium.

Denmark has a very extensive dictionary, apparently comprising more than twenty-three volumes. Immigrants often fail the Danish-language examination conducted for citizenship. A woman who had married a Dane, whose child had become a Danish citizen, said that the language paper was extremely difficult—even Danes would fail it. Having a small population or territory has not harmed the Danish vocabulary.

The fundamental concern of literature is its subject matter. But if writers themselves suffer from a scarcity of words, what can they communicate, and how can they clarify their material? Maithili will end up in the same condition as Hindi literature. The acceptability of a vocabulary should be determined by the words spoken in the villages of native speakers, not by the vocabulary of migrants estranged from the culture. The acceptability of a vocabulary should be determined by what native speakers say in their villages. If instead one makes the speech of culturally uprooted migrants the foundation, good literature will appear to have been excavated from the ground, while the literature praised by critics operating through literary cliques will seem natural.

The discipline of classical rules is for the writer, not the reader. If a writer composes ghazals, *rolās*, *dohās* and *kuṇḍaliyās* on their proper classical foundations, readers will enjoy them. If the writer shies away from effort, literary readership will diminish. Even the method of breaking the strictures of the *śāstra* is contained within the *śāstra* itself. Judged through

rigid classical rules, the Sāvitrī mantra does not conform to the Gāyatrī metre; yet we count it as Gāyatrī because *svaḥ* is made *suvaḥ* to complete the metrical count.

Mazhar Imam of Darbhanga received the Sahitya Akademi Award for Urdu for *Pichhle Mausam Ka Phool*. The collection contains fifty-five ghazals in *bahr* and three free ghazals without *bahr*. Readers remember him for his ghazals; it does not matter to them whether a ghazal they liked was in metre or not. They liked it. Is it then mere coincidence that the ghazals they liked happened to be in *bahr*? Urdu literature remembers Mazhar Imam as the figure who established the free ghazal.

A writer's ideology should be like salt dissolved in water, not oil floating on water; I have written about this before. Yatri and Dhumketu needed the support of the Communist Party because the Left was a fashion for them, like a "good scent" or "designer wear". Thus Balchanma, after turning away from the Congress and Socialist parties, looks to the Communists and the red flag for the solution to every problem; Yatri supplies him with every solution there. For Dhumketu's characters, too, the red flag is a kind of *Lakṣmaṇa-būṭī*, a life-restoring herb. But these writers were not connected with the Communist movement except as a fashion, and their ideology consequently spreads over their literature like oil. Now consider the Maithili literature of Chaturanand Mishra and Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Have you seen the red flag or the Communist Party mentioned anywhere in Chaturanand Mishra's novels or Jagdish Prasad Mandal's writing? What one encounters here is the genuinely leftist dialectical method and a faith in life: ideology dissolved like salt. Is it merely a coincidence that Chaturanand Mishra writes at the beginning of his life and Jagdish Prasad Mandal in its later years, after the last legal case was over?
The landlord Thakurji of Berma, Jagdish Prasad Mandal's village, told my paternal cousin that Jagdish Prasad Mandal was as truthful as Harishchandra and was the pride of the village. This was despite the fact that Mandal had led the Communist movement, had been imprisoned ten times and had fought legal cases against these very people. One consequence is that today nobody in Berma has a holding larger than ten bighas. Even now Mandal lives in a thatched house. He gets up at three in the morning, lights a small oil lamp and writes Maithili literature; his son has never seen him writing and does not know when he writes. Under Bhogendra Jha's leadership he had taken a vow that whenever he spoke, he would speak in Maithili. His son has therefore never heard him speak any language other than Maithili.
This is why his subject matter is new, and why his vocabulary is that of a native speaker, adequate and essential for clarifying that subject matter. His people, trees, leaves and flowers, fields and threshing grounds are real, grounded in lived experience, not excavated from below the earth. Inspired

by him, new writers living away from Mithila should learn Mithila's history, geography and culture before writing in Maithili; only then can their writing become distinctive. Read Radhakrishna Choudhary's *History of Mithila* and Jagdish Prasad Mandal's *Village Life* at https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-pothi/; for Maithili vocabulary see http://videha.co.in/new_page_13.htm.

The opinions of people like Thakurji of Berma matter more to me than those of writers and critics engaged in clique-making. It is no longer hidden from anyone how the literature of imported vocabulary has diminished Maithili's readership, whereas authentic vocabulary has raised the level of Maithili literature and increased its readers.

J. M. Coetzee, twice awarded the Booker Prize for fiction and awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature, once observed in relation to language that writing in English within a bilingual Afrikaans-and-English environment presented many problems of communication for him. In response, he translated extensively from Afrikaans into English. One can only hope that Maithili Sahitya Akademi Award winners—and certain aspirants to that award—who call themselves writers and are damaging the literary environment by holding on to both Maithili and Hindi will learn something from J. M. Coetzee.

In America there is an English "high-frequency" list of 350 words and a "basic word list" of 3,500 words for high-school students, which, as they advance to college and graduate school (where postgraduate study is called graduate school), roughly doubles for students outside language faculties. A student of literature or a writer is expected to command ten times as much. In Hindi, apart from exceptional regional works, poets and novelists compose literature—poetry and fiction—using a vocabulary of 2,000 words belonging to the eighth-grade level. Some Maithili writers want to import this basic 2,000-word list into Maithili and remain confined to it, while the signs of the Japanese writing system run to 500.

Taranand's casteism is of another kind. He writes: "Here a planned campaign is under way to heap a mountain of rubbish on the frail body of Maithili. An army of sweepers will be required to clean it. That is quite right. First it will be said that Maithili is the language of Brahmins; next it will be said that Maithili is the language of sweepers." At https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-audio/ there are audio recordings of people belonging to various castes of Mithila, and at https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-video/ there are video recordings, including recordings of Dom-Mallik people—whom Viyogi calls sweepers and whose language and community he despises—made available through the courtesy of Shri Umesh Mandal. The manner in which Mahendra Malangia's *Kāṭhak Lok* and *Okar Āṅgank Bārahmāsā*

began what I regard as hatred and propaganda against an allegedly distinct Dalit Maithili invented by Malangia has been carried forward by Taranand Viyogi. These audio and video recordings have decisively put an end to that hatred and propaganda, and the world can hear and see that Maithili does not differ on a caste basis in the way alleged. Viyogi puts his energies to negative uses, because his perspective and ideology lack clarity; he therefore cannot bear criticism from others. His comment on a Videha editorial was answered by Avinash (now Avinash Das) on his Facebook wall.

Responding to that same editorial, Gangesh Gunjan wrote that the assertion by the young Subhash Chandra—"Five years ago Gangesh Gunjan said in Kamani Auditorium that he writes in Hindi, but the Maithili people gave him an award"—was untrue. Gunjan said that he had never made such a statement. Subhash Chandra did not reply, so Gunjan's account must be accepted. Dr Dhanakar Thakur was also distressed by criticism of the Sahitya Akademi and sent several emails to Shri Umesh Mandal, co-editor of Videha. He does not support the genuinely standardised language of Jagdish Prasad Mandal and Umesh Mandal.
When Umesh Mandal initiated a debate on linguistics, he declared himself a doctor and did not take part in the debate. Apart from the emails, he and many others were heard at *Sagar Rati Deep Jaray* in Hazaribagh saying: "Do not write this way; write like Ashok, Shrinivas and the others; read first and then write like them"—assuming that those writers write without reading.
Benipuri's drama *Ambapali* is in Hindi, and NCERT included it in the school syllabus. The editors said that the absence of the verb "hai", as in "vah jā rahā", resulted from Benipuri's regional background. Respecting the play's historical character, the editorial board therefore did not edit it even though it was part of the school curriculum. Yet when Umesh Mandal, Jagdish Prasad Mandal or Ram Vilas Sahu writes "ओ जाइत", "ओ खाइत", experts at *Sagar Rati*, unfamiliar with linguistics, offer advice that would make a fundamental feature of Maithili secondary. Benipuri's Hindi, influenced by Maithili, escapes the NCERT editor's intervention in the name of Maithili, but casteism within Maithili is determined not to spare comparable usage in Maithili itself.
That casteist mentality will severely affect the outcome of the CIIL translation mission as well, because translation workshops are being conducted on the basis of pseudo-standardisation. Until the supposedly established or award-winning writers of Maithili recognise genuine standardisation, their standing before the extraordinary, even "monstrous", talent described above—in both subject matter and language—will remain diminished.

1. A casteist mentality means treating a deed as good simply because someone of one's own inherited caste did it; anyone may have such a mentality.

Pseudo-standardisation: the result of promoting the ideas of a particular casteist school; CIIL has published a book or two in Maithili, while its standardisation project has continued for years without producing a result.

Genuine standardisation: standard Maithili developed through intensive discussion of the Maithili spoken by people of all castes in every region of Mithila. Examples appear in the writings of Bechan Thakur, Jagdish Prasad Mandal and others at https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-pothi/. Fieldwork is available at https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-audio/: forty-six audio files on rites, folk songs and customary songs from all castes and religions of Mithila, courtesy of Umesh Mandal; and at https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-video/.

The video collection contains forty-four files on rites, folk songs and customary songs from all castes and religions of Mithila (courtesy of Umesh Mandal), while a synthesis based on the views of 2,000 readers is available at http://www.videha.co.in/new_page_13.htm. The audio and video files constitute a final blow to the supposedly separate Maithili termed "शोल्कन्हक" that, in my view, was propagated or invented in Mahendra Malangia's *Kāṭhak Lok* and *Okar Āṅgank Bārahmāsā*.

"Monstrous talent": on one side stands the unread world of Brahminical Maithili writers, and on the other the widely read world of Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdev Mandal and Bechan Thakur. Brahminical Maithili writers might call the latter "monstrous talent" in a disparaging sense; in my view, it signals the beginning of the former's defeat.

2. Dhanakarji held the opinion—indeed, made the decision—that "रामनाथहुँ" should be used instead of "रामनाथोक"! The complete debate between Umesh Mandal and Dhanakar Thakur appeared in the editorial of the eighty-fourth issue of Videha.

3. The new issue of Videha contains Jagdish Prasad Mandal's long story *Shambhudas*. Consider its second paragraph:
"जहिना बाध-बोनक ओहन परती जइपर कहियो हर-कोदारि नै चलल सुखि-सुखि गाछ-विरिछ खसि उसर भऽ जाइत, ओइ परतीपर या तँ चिड़ै-चुनमुनीक माध्यमसँ वा हवा-पानिक माध्यमसँ अनेरूआ फूल-फड़क गाछ जनमि रौद-वसात, पानि-पाथर, अन्हर-विहाड़ि सहि अपन जुआनी पाबि छाती खोलि बाट-बटोहीकेँ अपन मीठ सुआदसँ तृप्ति करैत तहिना जमुना नदीक तटपर शंभूदासक जन्म बटाइ-किसान परिवारमे भेलनि।"
Just as a patch of uncultivated land amid fields and woodland, untouched

by plough or hoe, becomes barren when its trees dry up and fall, yet later gives birth to wild flowering and fruiting trees through birds or wind and water, trees that endure sun, rain, water, stones and storm, reach maturity and offer their sweet fruit to passers-by, so Shambhudas was born into a sharecropping family on the bank of the Jamuna River.

Is it necessary here to insert "अछि" after "जाइत" and "करैत"?

4. A few reflections: four commentaries in this context on news, events and publications concerning Maithili.

The initial effort of CIIL's translation mission consists of workshops of writers belonging to the unread world of Maithili literature. It is concerned neither with readers nor with the literature of writers who are genuinely read. Its outcome will therefore be the same as that of the Sahitya Akademi. Amarji writes that books published by the Sahitya Akademi are rotting in warehouses.

32. The Place of Maithili in the Indo-European Language Family

Abstract

The genealogical classification of languages rests on historical foundations: the history of a language, its descent from another language, its form and structure—in other words, its grammatical organisation—and its semantic elements are all considered. Just as a person or group imagines an ancestral founder and constructs a family tree from that person to the present, the historian of language proposes earlier and ancestral languages on the basis of ancient, medieval and modern periods.

Keywords: Indo-European · language family · place of Maithili · critical theory · Maithili

The genealogical classification of languages rests on historical foundations: the history of a language, its descent from another language, its form and structure—in other words, its grammatical organisation—and its semantic elements are all considered. Just as a person or group imagines an ancestral founder and constructs a family tree from that person to the present, the historian of language proposes earlier and ancestral languages on the basis of ancient, medieval and modern periods. The concepts of daughter languages and sister languages likewise arise in the history of language.

The Place of Maithili in the Indo-European Language Family

Languages are related to one another through geography, vocabulary, grammar and sound. There are, however, exceptions. Avestan, English and German, though geographically distant from Maithili, belong to the same family, whereas Arabic and Tamil, despite their relative geographical proximity, belong to different families.

Nor can we demonstrate that two languages belong to the same family merely because they contain borrowed foreign vocabulary. Similarity in the meanings of lexical roots or in sound also cannot place two language families in a single group—for example, Sanskrit *jālma* and Arabic *ẓālim* exhibit a lexical resemblance, while the Maithili *miyāũ* and Mandarin Chinese *miāo* (“cat”) show a resemblance in sound.

Phonetic resemblance, too, can be misleading. For instance, Maithili frequently uses ड़, ढ़ and the candrabindu, whereas these three sounds do not occur in Sanskrit.

Even on geographical grounds, the designation “Indo-European language” is not entirely appropriate, for the Indo-European family is not

present throughout India and other language families also exist there. In Europe as well, the Caucasian and other language families do not belong to the Indo-European family.

Similarity of grammar offers the strongest basis for placing two languages within one family.

Indo-European languages originally make extensive use of suffixes: words are formed by adding suffixes to roots. They have three grammatical genders—masculine, feminine and neuter—and three numbers—singular, dual and plural. Most languages now have only singular and plural. Indo-European languages also possess two categories of verbal form: *ātmanepada*, in which the result of an action accrues to the agent, and *parasmaipada*, in which it accrues to someone else. Compounding, broadly speaking, is another characteristic of Indo-European languages.

The Indo-European family has two divisions. The original Indo-European word for a hundred, "क्मतोम", is pronounced in two ways: Sanskrit *śatam* and Latin *centum*. On this basis, the group close to Sanskrit includes Avestan (both the name of a language and of a text; the Zend-Avesta is its commentary), Persian, Maithili, Russian and others. The *centum* group includes languages close to Latin, such as Greek, German, French and Italian.

The *śatam* group includes Indo-Iranian (or Indo-Aryan), Balto-Slavic, Armenian and Illyrian language groups.

The Rigveda is the earliest text within the Indo-Aryan or Indo-Iranian language group. The Avesta, the sacred text of Zoroastrianism dating from the Vedic period, is written in Avestan. The chief Iranian languages include Avestan, Old Persian, Pahlavi, Pashto, Balochi and Kurdish. The Indian Aryan group includes Vedic Sanskrit, Classical Sanskrit, Pali (early Prakrit, from 500 BCE to 100 BCE), Prakrit (Middle Prakrit, from 100 BCE to 500 CE), Apabhraṃśa (500–900 CE), Avahaṭṭa (900–1100 CE), and thereafter Maithili, Bengali, Odia, Assamese and other languages derived from Māgadhī Prakrit (from 1100 CE).

Genealogical Classification of the World's Languages

(a) Eurasia; (b) Africa; (c) the Pacific region; (d) the Americas.

(a) Eurasia: (i) Indo-European, (ii) Dravidian, (iii) Burushaski, (iv) Caucasian, (v) Ural-Altaic, (vi) Chinese, (vii) Japanese-Korean, (viii) Hyperborean, (ix) Basque and (x) Semitic-Hamitic—the latter also occurring in Africa.

(i) Indo-European: (1) Indo-Aryan, (2) Balto-Slavic, (3) Armenian, (4) Illyrian, (5) Greek, (6) Celtic, (7) Germanic, (8) Italic, (9) Hittite and (10) Tocharian.

(1) Indo-Aryan: (a) Indian Aryan languages and (b) Iranian.

(a) Indian Aryan Languages

(A) Ancient Indian Aryan languages (2500–500 BCE).

(B) Medieval Indian Aryan languages (500 BCE–1000 CE).

(C) Modern Indian Aryan languages (1000 CE to the present).

(A) Ancient Indian Aryan languages (2500–500 BCE): Vedic Sanskrit and Classical Sanskrit (Valmiki's "मानुषिमिह संस्कृताम्"—both Sanskrit and the language of human beings).

(B) Medieval Indian Aryan languages (500 BCE–1000 CE): first Prakrit (Pali); second Prakrit (literary Prakrit—Śaurasenī, Mahārāṣṭrī, Māgadhī, Ardhamāgadhī, Paiśācī, Brācaḍa and Khas); third Prakrit (Apabhraṃśa, first mentioned by Vyāḍi and Patañjali).

(C) Modern Indian Aryan languages (1000 CE to the present): (a) from Śaurasenī: Kharī Bolī, Brajbhāṣā, Bāṅgarū, Kannaujī, Bundelī, Mārwāṛī, Jaipurī, Mālvī, Mewātī and Gujarātī; (b) from Mahārāṣṭrī: Marāṭhī, Konkani, Nāgpurī and Barārī; (c) from Māgadhī: Bhojpurī, Magahī, Bengali, Odia, Assamese and Maithili; (d) from Ardhamāgadhī: Avadhī, Baghelī and Chhattīsgaṛhī; (e) from Paiśācī: Lahndā; (f) from Brācaḍa: Sindhī and Panjābī; and (g) from Khas: the Pahari languages. These lines of development are thus traced.

In the Sundarakāṇḍa, Vālmīki has Hanuman speak of his knowledge of both Sanskrit and the human language through the expression "मानुषिमिह संस्कृताम्." Jyotirishwar asks, "And what kind of bard is he? One who knows the essential character of all six languages—Sanskrit, Prakrit, Avahaṭṭa, Paiśācī, Śaurasenī and Māgadhī." Jyotirishwar also discusses seven "sub-languages." Prakrit had several forms, of which Māgadhī Prakrit contributed to the development of Maithili and the other languages of eastern India. Jain religious texts were written in Ardhamāgadhī, and Buddhist religious texts in Pali. In Kālidāsa's Sanskrit plays, Apabhraṃśa, besides Sanskrit, was employed for characters outside the elite, while the language of the Caryāpada was also an Apabhraṃśa mixed with Māgadhī. The other modern Indo-Aryan languages, including Maithili, also appear to have developed from the second Prakrit. In a later period, Apabhraṃśa took the form of Avahaṭṭa in eastern India. Features characteristic of Maithili—its words ending in vowels, its complex verbal forms without distinctions of gender, and the outlines of its pronominal

and genitive forms—had already begun to appear in Avahaṭṭa. This is why Avahaṭṭa (Avahaṭṭha) is called "Maithil Apabhraṃśa" in the historical classification of language families, and its development from Māgadhī Prakrit can also be observed. Although close to Maithili, Avahaṭṭa is also close to Śaurasenī Prakrit and Apabhraṃśa; nevertheless, through its use of indigenous words it displays many grammatical changes from Apabhraṃśa. Vidyapati's Kīrtilatā is in Avahaṭṭa, whereas the Caryā songs and Varṇaratnākara, though earlier than Kīrtilatā, are in Old Maithili and are also close to Avahaṭṭa. Dāmodara Paṇḍit's Ukti-Vyakti-Prakaraṇa likewise precedes Kīrtilatā, but represents Old Awadhi and Old Kosali and is close to Avahaṭṭa. Broadly speaking, Maithili's position within the Indo-European language family emerges through the historical sequence Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit, Apabhraṃśa and Avahaṭṭa.

At the origin of Maithili—or of any language—we must establish the emergence of sounds from the human mouth and the association of those sounds with objects, persons or ideas. Birds, small creatures, cattle and even a person unable to speak can produce sounds; but those sounds do not acquire such meanings and therefore do not constitute a language.

In Paris in 1866, the organisation called "La Société de Linguistique" excluded "the origin of language and the formation of the languages of the world" from the business of its governing body, because discussion of the subject, being based on conjecture, was considered remote from a scientific approach.

A sequence can be traced from Vedic Sanskrit to Classical Sanskrit, and thence to Pali, Prakrit, Apabhraṃśa, Avahaṭṭa and Maithili. But Vedic Sanskrit must have existed before the Rigveda, its oldest surviving text. Much oral literature—gāthās, nārāśaṃsīs, tales of deities and narratives—may have been composed in it. For singers of such gāthās, the Rigveda uses words such as "gāthin," "gātuvid" and "gāthapati." Whether Vedic Sanskrit came into existence by divine agency, or arose in order to extend communication beyond bodily and verbal signs, remains a matter of conjecture. Changes in speech sounds, words, grammatical units, sentences and meanings led from Vedic to Classical Sanskrit, and subsequently to Pali, Prakrit, Apabhraṃśa, Avahaṭṭa and Maithili. By incorporating vocabulary from different regions of India, Pāṇini enriched Classical Sanskrit to such an extent that numerous linguistic forms could emerge from it. Regional varieties of Prakrit and Apabhraṃśa arose across these geographical areas, and from them developed the modern Indo-Aryan languages of today.

Maithili belongs to the Indo-European language family. Approximately forty per cent of the world's population falls within this family. It is the largest language family, and the richest as well. Broadly, it has two

divisions: first, the Aryan languages of Europe; and second, the Indo-Iranian branch. The Indo-Iranian Aryan languages include Iranian, Dardic and Indo-Aryan. Dardic includes Kashmiri and the languages to the east and south of the Pamir plateau. The origin and development of Maithili must be sought within Indo-Aryan.

The origin of language is itself a matter of conjecture. Many years pass between a language's beginning, its use, and the composition of literature in it; only then does its form become stable. The earliest text of Vedic Sanskrit is the Rigveda; of Classical Sanskrit, Vālmīki's Rāmāyaṇa; of Pali, the Buddhist Tripiṭaka; of Prakrit, Vimalasūri's Paumacariu; and of Apabhraṃśa, Yogīndra's Paramātmaprakāśa. Early Maithili literature includes Siddha literature, Buddhist songs and Jyotirishwar's Varṇaratnākara. The Siddha Saraha (Sarhapāda), dated 700–780, wrote: "सिद्धिरत्थु मइ पढमे पढिअउ, मण्ड पिबन्तौ बिसरउ एमइउ." In Mithila, the beginning of learning the alphabet is marked by "siddhirastu" (drawing the hook of Gaṇeśa). There is a belief in Mithila that drinking the starchy water from boiled rice weakens memory. Another example reads: "बलद बियायल गबैया बाँझे"—the bull has calved and the cow is barren.

Medieval Maithili literature includes Vidyapati's Maithili writings and, after him, the works of Chatur Chaturbhuj, Śaṅkaradeva and various Malla kings, the kīrtaniyā and aṅkiyā plays, and works down to Manbodh. Modern Maithili literature begins with Chanda Jha.

The geographical domain of the Aryan languages in ancient India, and their subsequent spread into other regions, can be determined from the rivers described in the Rigveda, the oldest text of Vedic Sanskrit. The Rigvedic Aryans inhabited the region called "Sapta Sindhava," the land of seven rivers: Vitastā, Aśkinī, Paruṣṇī, Śatudru, Vipāśā, Krumu and Gomatī. The first five flowed in Punjab and the remaining two in Afghanistan. All seven were tributaries of the Sindhu, the most important river of the Rigvedic period. The Sarasvatī is described in the Rigveda as the "mother of rivers." The Yamunā is mentioned twice and the Gaṅgā once. The hymn of praise to rivers in the Rigveda's tenth maṇḍala praises the Sindhu and the Sapta-Saindhava region. Five peoples lived then, known as the Pūru, Anu, Druhyu, Yadu and Turvaśa. The Krivi and Tṛtsu were also present. The Pūru and the most powerful Bharata tribe later joined to form the Kuru tribe. In the Battle of the Ten Kings, the Bharata tribe defeated a confederation of five Aryan and five non-Aryan tribes. Vasiṣṭha was priest to the Bharatas; Viśvāmitra served the confederation of the five Aryan and five non-Aryan (*dasyu*) tribes. The fourteenth-century BCE inscription of a Hittite ruler at Boğazköy in Asia Minor mentions kings such as Indra, Daśaratha and Artatama, and deities including Indra, Varuṇa and the

Nāsatyas. The Vajasaneyi recension of the Yajurveda, the Kauthuma recension of the Sāmaveda, and the Chāndogya Āraṇyaka and Upaniṣad of the Sāmaveda underlie the vertical division of Mithila's Brahmins into Vajasaneyi and Chāndogya traditions, which continues to this day. Videha is mentioned in the Yajurveda, and a Vedic Janaka in the Rigveda (Sīradhvaja Janaka, Sītā's father, came later).

The "king of Videha" in the Rigvedic period was Nami Sāpya. The Rigveda relates that, while performing a sacrifice, he ascended bodily to heaven. He sided with Indra against the asura Namuci, and Indra saved him. Videgha Māthava of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa and Nimi of the Purāṇas both have Gautama as their priest; therefore they are the same person, and the kingdom of Videha begins here. Māthava's priest Gautama introduced the Mitravinda sacrifice, and it was re-established by Yājñavalkya in the time of Mahājanaka II. Near Gautama's hermitage, Nimi founded Jayanta and Mithi—also remembered as Mithilā—built the city of Mithila. Nimi's Jayantapura was at present-day Janakpur; the site of Mithi's city of Mithila has not yet been established, though it is presumed to have been near Janakpur. Sīradhvaja Janaka was Sītā's father, and from this point a strong tradition of the kings of Mithila becomes visible. Kṛti Janaka was in the eighteenth generation after Sīradhvaja. Kṛti was the son of Hiraṇyanābha, while Janaka was the son of Bahulāśva. Yājñavalkya was Hiraṇyanābha's pupil and received instruction in yoga from him. Karāla Janaka attempted to violate a Brahmin maiden's chastity, and the Janaka dynasty came to an end (see Aśvaghoṣa's Buddhacarita and Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra). The Arthaśāstra also discusses the downfall of Karāla Janaka (Book I, Chapter 6, on mastery of the senses and abandonment of the six enemies):
"तद्विरुद्धवृत्तिरवश्येन्द्रियश्चातुरन्तोऽपि राजा सद्यो विनश्यति—यथा दाण्डक्यो नाम भोजः कामाद् ब्राह्मण कन्यायमभिमन्यमानः सबन्धराष्ट्रो विननाश करालश्च वैदेहः, ..."

In the period of Vedic Sanskrit, the Aryans had moved from Sapta Sindhava to Videha. They had already come into contact with the non-Aryans (*dasyus*), and words were exchanged between their languages. This exchange is visible in the Yajurveda and later in the Atharvaveda. The speech of both the non-Aryans (*dasyus*) and the *vrātyas* (groups that had become Aryan from a non-Aryan background) mingled with that of the Aryans of the Sapta-Saindhava region. With the arrival of eastern and other regional influences, Vedic Sanskrit changed into Classical Sanskrit. By the time of the Nirukta, Vedic vocabulary had already become difficult and debate about its derivations had begun. Pāṇini's language was formed by absorbing words from the *dasyu* and *vrātya* languages of the eastern, southern, western and northern regions. This refined language subsequently became known among people as Sanskrit. Just as Pāṇini

called Classical Sanskrit "bhāṣā," so Yāska and Pāṇini called Vedic Sanskrit "chandas." It is this "chandas" that was called "Zend" in the commentary on the Avestan language.

Sanskrit, Prakrit, Avahaṭṭa, Maithili

1. Sanskrit

Apart from differences of script, the languages of northern India, Nepal and southern India (except Tamil) use a comparable alphabetic arrangement of vowels and the consonant series *ka, ca, ṭa, ta, pa*, followed by *ya, ra, la, va, śa, sa* and *ha*. Sanskrit also possesses an additional sound, *gvāṅ*, which is not pronounced in the Chāndogya tradition but is extensively used in the Vājasaneyī tradition: for example, Chāndogya "सभूमि" as against Vājasaneyī "सभूमीग्वंङ." Both short and long forms occur. In Mithilākṣara, at least six forms of a character are used for *siddhirastu*. Vedic Sanskrit uses the *udātta*, *anudātta* and *svarita* accents (respectively क॑, क॒ and क॑े); Marathi also uses ळ and the half-ऱ. In Maithili, the sign ऽ (*avagraha*, or *bikārī*) is used as in Sanskrit. Nowadays, to suit the available typing facilities, forms such as द' are also used instead of दऽ; this practice, however, indicates a technical deficiency in that font. The sign is not necessary after the long *ā*.

Just as Persian has *alif, be, se* and Roman letters are called A, B, C, the alphabets of Indian languages are broadly similar despite differences in their scripts.

The sounds of the alphabet are of two kinds, vowels and consonants. There are sixty-four sounds: twenty-two vowels and forty-two consonants.

A vowel is defined as a sound whose pronunciation does not depend upon the pronunciation of another sound.

Vowels are of three kinds: short (*hrasva*), long (*dīrgha*) and protracted (*pluta*). A short vowel takes one unit of time to pronounce, a long vowel two and a protracted vowel three.

The basic vowels are अ इ उ ऋ ऌ.

Grammarians before Pāṇini called them *samānākṣara*.

The long compound vowels are ए ऐ ओ औ.

Grammarians before Pāṇini called them *sandhyakṣara*.

The vowel ऌ has no long form, while the compound vowels have no short forms.

The short, long (आ, ई, ऊ, ॠ) and protracted (आ३, ई३, ऊ३, ॠ३) forms of अ, इ, उ and ऋ amount to twelve sounds. ऌ has two forms, short and protracted (ऌ३), adding two; and the four long compound vowels ए, ऐ, ओ and औ also have protracted forms (ए३, ऐ३, ओ३, औ३), adding eight. Thus there are twenty-two vowels in all.

Each of these twenty-two vowels has three Vedic accentual forms: *udātta*, *anudātta* and *svarita*.

Sounds such as अ, produced at a higher point—for example, the palate—possess the quality of *udātta* and are therefore called *udātta*.

Vowels produced at a lower point are *anudātta*. A vowel such as अ, whose first portion is pronounced with *udātta* and whose second with *anudātta*, is *svarita*.

Vowels have two further varieties: nasalised, such as अँ, and non-nasalised, such as अ.

"दत्तेन निर्वृत्तः कूपो दात्तः": a well built by a man named Datta on the northern bank of the Vipāṭ or Vyāsa river was called *Dātta*. With the affix *añ*, *dātta* bears the initial *udātta*; with the affix *aṇ*, the accent would fall on the suffix and the final syllable would be *udātta*. The form remains the same, but the accent differs. This establishes that even ordinary cultivators pronounced words with tonal accents.

Another way to understand *svarita* is as a repetition of the final vowel at a more intense pitch.

We now turn to consonants.

There are forty-two consonants:

क् ख् ग् घ् ङ्
च् छ् ज् झ् ञ्
ट् ठ् ड् ढ् ण्
त् थ् द् ध् न्
प् फ् ब् भ् म्
य् र् ल् व्
श् ष् स्
ह्

The sounds य्, व् and ल् may also be nasalised (यँ, वँ, लँ) or non-nasalised.

There are two further consonantal sounds: *anusvāra* and *visarjanīya* or *visarga*.

Both are employed after vowels.

Visarjanīya is not a basic sound but a modification of स् or र्. According to certain phonetic and formal distinctions, it has two kinds, *jihvāmūlīya* and *upadhmānīya*. The first occurs only before क and ख, and the second only before प and फ.

Anusvāra, visarjanīya, jihvāmūlīya and *upadhmānīya* are called *ayogavāha*.

Apart from the sounds above, four further sounds are known as *yama*: कुँ खुँ गुँ घुँ (as in the forms पलिक् क्नी, चख ख्नुतः, अग् ग्निः and घ् घ्नन्ति).

A *yama* is an intervening sound resembling the preceding sound when the fifth consonant of a series follows it.
The *yama* sounds are also *ayogavāha*.
अ and आ, the *ka* group, uncombined ह्, and *visarjanīya* are pronounced in the throat.
इ and ई, the *ca* group, य and श are pronounced at the palate.
ऋ and ॠ, the *ṭa* group, र and ष are pronounced at the cerebral or retroflex point.
ऌ, the *ta* group, ल and स are pronounced at the teeth.
उ and ऊ, the *pa* group and *upadhmānīya* are pronounced at the lips.
व is pronounced with the lower lip assisted by the upper teeth.
ए and ऐ are pronounced at the throat and palate.
ओ and औ are pronounced at the throat and lips.
In pronouncing य, र, ल and व, the tip and other parts of the tongue do not make complete contact with the palate and other places of articulation as they do with other consonants. Nor do they produce friction against the palate and other articulatory points as श्, ष्, स् and ह् do.
The letters from क to म are stops or plosives: the air stream is obstructed by the tongue and then released. The sounds from र to व are semivowels, and those from ष to ह are fricatives.
The fifth sound in each consonantal group is nasal, because although its other articulatory positions remain the same, it is pronounced through the nose as well: air passes through both nose and mouth.
Anusvāra and *yama* are pronounced only through the nose and are called *nāsikya*, because the mouth remains closed while air escapes through the nose. One must not pronounce न् or म् in place of *anusvāra*.
When we wish to speak, intention stimulates the *jaṭharāgni*, the internal fire. Air near the navel rises forcefully towards the head, is obstructed by the tip and other parts of the tongue, and then rubs against the palate and other parts of the mouth, producing speech sounds. Vibrating air acquires resonance; when it reaches the mouth with this resonance, the sound is *ghoṣavān* (voiced). When it passes without resonance as breath, it is *aghoṣavān* (voiceless).
Sounds characterised by breath are *aghoṣa*, while those characterised by resonance are *ghoṣavān*. Sounds produced with less breath are *alpaprāṇa* (unaspirated); those produced with a greater outflow of breath are *mahāprāṇa* (aspirated).
In each of the *ka, ca, ṭa, ta* and *pa* series, the first, third and fifth sounds are *alpaprāṇa*, while the second and fourth are *mahāprāṇa*. The first and second are *aghoṣa*, while the third, fourth and fifth are *ghoṣavān*. The sounds य, र, ल and व are voiced and unaspirated; श, ष and स are voiceless

and aspirated; ह is voiced and aspirated. Vowels are unaspirated and may bear *udātta*, *anudātta* or *svarita* accent.

A composition governed by metre is called verse; otherwise it is prose. *Chandas*, or metre, denotes a composition that gives pleasure. This does not mean, however, that modern new poetry belongs to the category of prose. Even the Sāvitrī-Gāyatrī mantra of the Vedas is classified under Gāyatrī metre according to more flexible or liberal rules. These will be discussed below: where the required syllables are lacking, one or two syllables may be added to each *pāda*, and conjuncts containing य and व may be separated by inserting इ and उ respectively. Thus वरेण्यम् becomes वरेणियम्.

स्वः = सुवः.

For contemporary new poetry, including haiku, *kṣaṇikā* and *haikū*, Maithili and the Indian script system derived from Sanskrit are particularly suitable. Except Tamil, all the southern scripts and the scripts of northern, western and eastern India, including Devanagari, share the same arrangement of vowels and the *ka, ca, ṭa, ta, pa* consonants, in which what is written is what is pronounced. The short इ in Devanagari, however, is an exception: it is written before the consonant but pronounced after it. In Maithili, even this exception does not arise. Thus "अछि" is pronounced as अ + short इ + छ, or अ + इ + छ. Take another example: "राति"—रा + इ + त. This establishes Maithili as the best language for haiku. Consider another example. *Sandhi* is a characteristic of Sanskrit; but is there no *sandhi* in English? What, then, is "आइम गोइङ टूवाड्र्सदएन्ड"? It is written "आइ एम गोइङ टूवाड्र्स द एन्ड" ("I am going towards the end"). Pāṇini formulated rules of *sandhi* on phonetic principles. In written English, however, *sandhi* is not observed in this way: "I am" may be written phonetically as "I'm," but the joining of sounds takes place in speech. In Maithili, too, case markers are, wherever possible, written and pronounced attached to the word.

Metres are of two kinds: quantitative metres, based on *mātrās*, and syllabic metres, based on *varṇas*.

The Vedas employ syllabic metres rather than quantitative metres.

In syllabic metres, only the number of sounds or syllables is counted. A letter bearing a *halant* is not counted separately. A syllable bearing the signs of ए, उ and similar vowels is counted as one, as is a conjunct consonant. The letters from अ to ह are also each counted as one. No letter

or syllable receives a value greater than one. Remember three points in particular:

1. A letter bearing a *halant*: 0.

2. A conjunct letter: 1.

3. Each letter from अ to ह: 1.

Consider the first example:

ई अरदराक मेघ नहि मानत रहत बरसि के = १+५ +२+२+३+३+३+१ = २०.

Now consider the second example:

पश्चात् = २.

Now the third example:

आब = २.

Now the fourth example:

स्क्रिप्ट = २.

There are seven principal Vedic metres:

Gāyatrī, Uṣṇik, Anuṣṭubh, Bṛhatī, Paṅkti, Triṣṭubh and Jagatī. All the others are their variations, including *atichandas* and *vichandas*. Here, metre is identified through syllables. Where the syllabic count falls short, one or two syllables may be added to each *pāda*. Conjuncts containing य and व may be separated by inserting इ and उ respectively. For example:

वरेण्यम् = वरेणियम्.

स्वः = सुवः.

The syllabic count can also be completed by separating the sounds involved in *guṇa* and *vṛddhi*.

ए = अ + इ.

ओ = अ + उ.

ऐ = अ/आ + ए.

औ = अ/आ + ओ.

Consider the categories *guru* and *laghu* used in the science of prosody.

Among the thirteen vowel signs, five—अ, इ, उ, ऋ and ऌ—are short, while eight—आ, ई, ऊ, ॠ, ए, ऐ, ओ and औ—are long.

When these vowel sounds are joined to consonants, they form *guṇitākṣara*, or modified syllabic characters.

क् + अ = क.

क् + आ = का.

One vowel or one *guṇitākṣara* is called a syllable (*akṣara*). A bare consonant is not regarded as a syllable; thus the word "अवाक्" contains two syllables, अ and वा.

1. All short vowels and modified syllables containing a short vowel are regarded as *laghu* (light). They are marked with a U placed above them.

2. All long vowels and modified syllables containing a long vowel are regarded as *guru* (heavy). Their sign is a short horizontal stroke placed above.

3. All syllables bearing *anusvāra* or *visarga* are regarded as *guru.*

4. When a syllable is followed by a conjunct consonant or a bare consonant, that syllable is regarded as *guru*. For example, in "अच्" and "सत्य," both अ and स are *guru.*

5. Just as syllabic metres or *vṛttas* were employed in the Vedas, so too—

A comprehensive consideration of vocal accent is also found from that period. Broadly, it is divided into seven types: (1) *udātta*, (2) *udāttatara*, (3) *anudātta*, (4) *anudāttatara*, (5) *svarita*, (6) *anudāttānurakta-svarita*, and (7) *pracaya* (a heard, unstruck sound—*anāhata nāda*—arising without contact with any object; the others are struck sounds, *āhata nāda*, produced when objects strike one another).

Vedic Recitation

3. Jagatī: four *pādas* of twelve syllables each.

ए = अ + इ.

ओ = अ + उ.

ऐ = अ/आ + ए.

औ = अ/आ + ओ.

The Grammar of Vedic Sanskrit (*Chandas*) and Classical Sanskrit (*Bhāṣā*)

In both Vedic and Classical Sanskrit, nouns, pronouns and adjectives have three grammatical genders—masculine, feminine and neuter—and three

numbers—singular, dual and plural. The grammatical genders do not necessarily indicate biological sex: *dārā* is masculine, *kalatra* neuter and *bhāryā* feminine, although all three signify a wife. Likewise, *īśvaraḥ* is masculine, *brahma* neuter and *citiḥ* feminine. Nouns, pronouns and adjectives also have eight cases (*vibhaktis*). Verbal roots are divided into ten classes and have three types of forms: *parasmaipada* (the result accrues to another), *ātmanepada* (the result accrues to oneself) and *ubhayapada* (both). There are three voices or modes of expression—*kartṛ*, *karma* and *bhāva*—and twelve *lakāras*: *laṭ, liṭ, laṅ, luṅ, luṭ, lṛṭ, loṭ, vidhiliṅ, āśīrliṅ, lṛṅ, leṭ* and *leṅ*. The last two, *leṭ* and *leṅ*, do not occur in Classical Sanskrit (*bhāṣā*).

Sanskrit distinguishes three grammatical persons: *prathama* (corresponding to the third person in other languages), *madhyama* (second person) and *uttama* (first person). There is mutual agreement of grammatical features between subject and predicate, agent and verb, the qualified noun and its qualifier, and noun and pronoun.

Vedic Sanskrit possessed both melodic and stress accents, whereas Classical Sanskrit retained only stress accent. The Vedic pronunciation of *udātta, anudātta* and *svarita* (compare the ascending, descending and level movements of musical theory) disappeared from Classical pronunciation.

In Vedic metres, the syllables are counted within each quarter-verse, called a *pāda*. Metre also has *gati* (rhythmic movement) and *yati* (pause). A short vowel is *laghu*; when followed by a conjunct consonant, a short vowel becomes *guru*.

Prefixes: In Classical Sanskrit, a prefix stands before the verb. In Vedic Sanskrit it may stand before the verb, after it, separately, or even at some distance. Moreover, once a prefix has been used with a verb in a Vedic mantra, the prefix alone may appear later in the mantra while still referring to that prefixed verb.

Compounds: Vedic Sanskrit sometimes differs in its treatment of compounds. For example, when a word follows *aṣṭa*, the form becomes *aṣṭā*, as in *aṣṭāpadī*. In a copulative compound of *pitṛ* and *mātṛ*, both take long आ and undergo *guṇa*: *pitarāmātarā*.

The *leṭ lakāra*: The *leṭ* form is not used in Classical Sanskrit but is found in Vedic Sanskrit, as in *bhavāti* and *patāti*, corresponding to the Classical *bhavati* and *patati*.

Vedic and Classical Sanskrit are not two different languages; rather, Classical Sanskrit is a simpler form of Vedic Sanskrit. Vedic Sanskrit has a wider range of forms and features than Classical Sanskrit (with the

exception that the *luṭ* and *lṛṭ* forms are used less frequently in Vedic Sanskrit).

The language of the Saṃhitās, Brāhmaṇa texts, Āraṇyakas and Upaniṣads is called Vedic Sanskrit; the Sanskrit of subsequent periods is called Classical Sanskrit.

In both forms of Sanskrit, verbal roots, words and meanings are generally the same.

Both have three genders, three numbers and three grammatical persons.

In both, almost all words are derived from roots; conventional, non-derivable words are very few.

Compounds occur in both, though they are employed more extensively in Classical Sanskrit.

The metres in both are also broadly alike.

The division of verbal roots into classes is likewise the same in both.

The *ṇic* and *san* suffixes are found in both.

Words are formed in the same way in both.

The *sup, tiṅ, kṛt* and *taddhita* forms and affixes are alike in both.

In neither form does a change in word order necessarily alter the meaning. Both possess *sandhi*, case relations and inflectional endings.

But there are differences:

Classical Sanskrit does not use the *upadhmānīya* and *jihvāmūlīya* sounds, employing *visarga* in their place.

Vedic Sanskrit has the sounds ळ and ळ्ह, which Classical Sanskrit lacks.

In Vedic Sanskrit, ड between two vowels becomes ळ and ढ becomes ळ्ह. This does not occur in Classical Sanskrit.

The short and long forms of *gvāṅ* are absent from Classical Sanskrit. In the Yajurveda, *anusvāra* before ह, श, ष, स or र becomes *gvāṅ*.

The *udātta, anudātta* and *svarita* accents are not distinctly pronounced in Classical Sanskrit.

The *leṭ lakāra* is used in Vedic Sanskrit but not in Classical Sanskrit.

In Vedic Sanskrit a prefix may be separated from the root, whereas in Classical Sanskrit it occurs together with it.

Vedic Sanskrit employs some fifteen *kṛt* affixes in the domain of *tumun*, including *se, sen, ase* and *adhyai*, whereas Classical Sanskrit employs only the *tum* affix.

The rules of *sandhi* are flexible in Vedic Sanskrit but strict in Classical Sanskrit.

The meanings of numerous Vedic words changed in Classical Sanskrit. Thus *asura* meant a powerful being in Vedic Sanskrit, but came to signify a demon in Classical Sanskrit.

The verbal forms also differ in Vedic Sanskrit; a final vowel may be lengthened, as in चक्र—चक्रा. Reduplication may be absent, as when दाति occurs in place of ददाति. Sometimes an *ātmanepada* root is used in place of a *parasmaipada* root, or the reverse; and an infix (*vikaraṇa*) associated with another verbal class may sometimes occur in place of *śap*.

Vedic Sanskrit has a greater variety of nominal forms, verbal forms and affixes.

The optional variations of tense, person, number and gender in Vedic Sanskrit have largely disappeared from Classical Sanskrit.

Vedic roots such as अच्, अम्, जिन्व् and पिन्व् are not used in Classical Sanskrit.

The comparative and superlative suffixes *tara* and *tama* are used in Vedic Sanskrit in a manner resembling nouns, but in Classical Sanskrit in a manner resembling adjectives.

For metrical purposes, Vedic Sanskrit may write स्वर् as सुवर्, and दर्शत as दरशत. This practice is not found in Classical Sanskrit.

In Vedic Sanskrit, when a word ends in "आन्" and is followed by the vowels अ, इ or उ, न् disappears and *anusvāra* appears after long आ. Thus महान् इन्द्रः = महा इन्द्रः. This does not occur in Classical Sanskrit.

Vedic Sanskrit: Verbal Forms

For the second-person plural *parasmaipada* in the *laṭ lakāra*, four endings occur: थ, त, थन and तन. Thus from वद् come वदथ, वदथन, वदत and वदतन.

For the first-person plural *parasmaipada* in the *laṭ lakāra*, two endings are used: मस् (मः) and मसि. Thus नाशयामः—नाशयामसि; इमः—इमसि; स्मः—स्मसि.

In the second-person singular *parasmaipada* of the *loṭ lakāra*, there are two endings, हि and धि, as in श्रुणुहि and श्रुणुधि.

In the second-person plural *ātmanepada* of the *loṭ lakāra*, two endings occur, ध्वम् and ध्वात्, as in वारयध्वम् and वारयध्वात्.

"छन्दसि लुङ् लङ् लिटः": In Vedic Sanskrit, *luṅ, laṅ* and *liṭ* forms may be employed with the meanings of *loṭ* and *laṭ*. For example, आगमत् (Vedic *luṅ*) = आगच्छतु (*loṭ*); अवृणीत (Vedic *laṅ*) = वृणीते (*laṭ*); and ममार (Vedic *liṭ*) = म्रियते (*laṭ*).

Vedic Sanskrit: Nominal Forms

[In संस्कृत, सं = स् + म is correct; pronouncing सं as स् + न is incorrect.]

Vedic Sanskrit has a greater variety of nominal forms than Classical Sanskrit. For example, with the masculine *a*-stem देवः, the nominative, accusative and vocative dual may be either देवा or देवौ in Vedic Sanskrit, but only देवौ in Classical Sanskrit. In the nominative and vocative plural, Vedic Sanskrit has देवासः and देवाः, whereas Classical Sanskrit has only देवाः. In the instrumental singular, Vedic Sanskrit has both देवा and देवेन, but Classical Sanskrit only देवेन. In the instrumental plural, Vedic Sanskrit has देवेभिः and देवैः, but Classical Sanskrit has देवैः.

Similarly, the masculine and feminine forms of words ending in ऋ are generally the same in Vedic and Classical Sanskrit, except that in the nominative, accusative and vocative dual two forms occur. Thus दातृः दातारा and दातारौ; पितृः पितरा and पितरौ; मातृः मातरा and मातरौ.

अस्मद्: nominative dual—Vedic वाम्, आवम्; Classical आवाम्. Dative singular—Vedic मह्य, मह्यम्; Classical मह्यम्. Ablative dual—Vedic आवत्, आवाभ्याम्; Classical आवाभ्याम्. Locative plural—Vedic अस्मे, अस्मासु; Classical अस्मासु.

Metre

In the eight chapters of the prosodic treatise of Piṅgala, Vedic metres are described up to the seventh sūtra of the fourth chapter; the subsequent portion describes Classical metres.

Vedic metres count syllables; there the distinction between *laghu* and *guru* is not considered. In the Rigveda, Triṣṭubh is used most frequently, followed by Gāyatrī and then Jagatī.

Triṣṭubh: forty-four syllables, arranged in four *pādas* of eleven syllables each.

Gāyatrī: twenty-four syllables. It may consist of two, three, four or five *pādas*. The most popular form has three *pādas* of eight syllables each, with a pause after the second *pāda*. The form with twenty-three syllables is called *nicṛd Gāyatrī*; that with twenty-two, *virāḍ Gāyatrī*; with twenty-five, *bhurig Gāyatrī*; and with twenty-six, *svarāḍ Gāyatrī*. When each *pāda* is short by one syllable, the form is called *pādanicṛd Gāyatrī*.

Jagatī: forty-eight syllables, in four *pādas* of twelve syllables each.

Recitation

There are several methods of memorising Vedic Sanskrit.

Saṃhitā-pāṭha: the original mantra is recited with *sandhi* and its proper accent.

Pada-pāṭha: the words of the mantra are recited separately.

Krama-pāṭha: successive pairs of words are recited in order.

Jaṭā-pāṭha: forward 1–2, reverse 2–1, then forward 1–2.

Śikhā-pāṭha: the following word, modified in *jaṭā-pāṭha*, is joined to form *śikhā-pāṭha*.

Ghana-pāṭha: the reversed words, released from the *śikhā* sequence, are recited again.

Vedic Sanskrit discusses sacrifice and spiritual subjects; Classical Sanskrit also takes up worldly themes.

2. Prakrit

Whether Prakrit preceded Sanskrit or came after it may be debated, because such words as शिथिर, दूलभ and इन्दर in the Rigveda furnish evidence of the literary adaptation of popular speech. Although instances of Prakrit usage can be found from Aśoka's inscriptions down to the thirteenth century CE, the Prakrits discussed here in the technical sense served as literary languages from approximately the first to the sixth century CE in two ways. First, Śaurasenī, Māhārāṣṭrī and Māgadhī were used for ordinary people and female characters in Sanskrit drama—Vararuci also adds Paiśācī as a fourth Prakrit. Examples include Kālidāsa's Abhijñānaśākuntalam and Mālavikāgnimitram, Śūdraka's Mṛcchakaṭikam, Śrīharṣa's Ratnāvalī, Bhavabhūti's Uttararāmacaritam and Viśākhadatta's Mudrārākṣasa. Second, literature subsequently began to be composed independently in these Prakrit languages. These Prakrits, too, were then bound by grammatical rules and became ornamented

literary languages; people began using Apabhraṃśa and Avahaṭṭa, although evidence also exists that Apabhraṃśa was used alongside Prakrit.

Among Aśoka's inscriptions, those at Shāhbāzgaṛhī and Mānsehrā represent the north-western regional forms of popular speech; Kālsī represents the central region; Dhauli and Jaugaḍa represent the eastern region; and Girnār represents the south-western region. Rājaśekhara calls Prakrit sweet and Sanskrit harsh. Vidyāpati later says, "देसिल बयना सभ जन मिट्ठा"—vernacular speech is sweet to everyone.

The earliest Prakrit is called Pali, in which Aśoka's inscriptions, the Mahāvaṃsa and the Jātakas were written. Middle Prakrit comprises the literary Prakrits. Later Prakrit includes Apabhraṃśa and Avahaṭṭa.

Broadly speaking, Śaurasenī was used for prose, Māhārāṣṭrī for poetry, and Māgadhī and Ardhamāgadhī for religious literature. In plays, women and jesters spoke Śaurasenī but recited verse in Māhārāṣṭrī; characters conventionally assigned a lower social rank spoke Māgadhī.

In Prakrit, the sup and tiṅ endings become fused with verbal roots.

In Prakrit, conjugational patterns were reduced to one or two types, as in the bhvādi class, while nominal declensions were reduced to three or four types, as with a-stem words. In other words, both sets of forms diminished in number. This created ambiguity of meaning, which case markers helped to resolve.

The dative, dual number, laṅ, liṭ and luṅ forms, and ātmanepada forms disappeared. The nominative and accusative plural came to have the same form. Sound changes occurred: ऋ, ऐ, औ, य, श, ष and visarga disappeared, with the exception that Māgadhī has य and श but not स.

Word-final consonants disappeared. After a short vowel no more than two consonants can remain, and after a long vowel no more than one.

2. Prakrit

In Prakrit, the sup and tiṅ endings become fused with verbal roots.

न changes to ण, य to ज, and श and ष to स.

In a compound, the initial letter of the second member is dropped, but such deletion does not occur if the form belongs to a verbal root. Thus आर्यपुत्र = अज्जउत्त, but आगतम् = आगदं.

The initial letter of an unaccented indeclinable is dropped; for example, च = अ.

The भ of the verbal root भू changes to ह; for example, भवति = होइ.

क changes to ख, and प to फ: पनस = फणस; क्रीड् = केल.

In a shift of place of articulation, a dental sound becomes palatal; for example, त् = च्.

Medial य disappears. Medial क, ग, च, ज, त and द also disappear, apart from certain exceptions; प, ब and व sometimes disappear as well. Examples: प्रिय = पिअ; लोक = लोअ; अनुराग = अणुराअ; प्रचुर = पउर; भोजन = भोअण; रसातल = रसाअल; हृदय = हिअअ; रूप = रूअ; विबुध = विउह; वियोग = विओअ.

Medial क, त and प become ग, द and ब respectively. ख, घ, थ, घ, फ and भ become ह. Examples: नायकः = णाअगु; आगतः = आगदो; दीप = दीब = दीव; मुख = मुह; सखी = सही; मेघ = मेह; लघुक = लहुअ; यूथ = जूह; रुधिर = रुहिर; वधू = वहू; शाफर = साहर; अभिनव = अहिणव.

Sometimes a medial consonant is doubled; for example, एक = एक्क.

Medial ट and ठ become ड and ढ respectively; for example, कुटुम्ब = कुडुम्ब and पठन = पढण.

Medial प and ब become व; for example, दीप = दीव and शबर = सवर.

ड, त and द become ल; for example, क्रीडा = कीला, सातवाहन = सालवाहण and दोहद = दोहल.

म becomes व; for example, ग्राम = गाँव.

A final stop consonant disappears. A word-final nasal does not take an anusvāra. The ending अः changes to ओ or disappears.

In general, only one consonant occurs at the beginning of a word, and no more than two consonants occur medially; the latter may appear as geminated forms such as क्क or क्ख.

Consonants follow this order of relative strength. First come the members of the क, च, ट, त and प series, from क, the strongest, towards भ, progressively weaker, excluding the fifth consonant of each series—that is, excluding ङ, ञ, ण, न and म. Next come those fifth consonants of the क, च, ट, त and प series. Finally come ल, स, व, य and र. If two consonants are equal in strength, the later consonant prevails; otherwise the stronger consonant prevails. Thus उत्पल = उप्पल; खड्ग = खग्ग; अग्नि = अग्गि. When the fifth consonant of one of these series meets another consonant

of its own series, the fifth remains unchanged; otherwise it becomes anusvāra. Thus क्रौञ्च = कोञ्च and दिङ्मुख = दिंमुह.

When ज्ञ occurs at the beginning of the second member of a compound, it becomes ज्ज: मनोज्ञ = मणोज्ज.

When श, ष or स follows a consonant of the क, च, ट, त or प series, the combination becomes च्छ; for example, अप्सरा = अच्छरा and मत्सर = मच्छर.

क्ष becomes क्ख; for example, दक्षिण = दक्खिण.

In Śaurasenī, क्ष becomes क्ख; in Māgadhī it becomes च्छ. Thus कुक्षि = कुक्खि in Śaurasenī and कुच्छि in Māgadhī.

The vowels ऋ and ऌ are absent from Prakrit. ऋ changes in several ways: (a) to रि, as in ऋषि = रिसि; (b) to अ, as in कृत = कद; (c) to इ, as in दृष्टि = दिट्ठि; and (d) to उ, as in पृच्छति = पुच्छदि.

ऐ and औ change to ए; for example, कौमुदी = कोमुदी.

A short vowel occurs before a conjunct consonant.

उ changes to अ or ओ; for example, मुकुल = मउल and पुस्तक = पोत्थअ.

ऊ changes to ओ; for example, मूल्य = मोल्ल.

ए changes to इ; for example, एतेन = एदिणा.

ओ changes to उ; for example, अन्योन्य = अण्णुण्ण.

Anusvāra + अपि becomes पि, and anusvāra + इति becomes ति. खलु becomes ख.

य् changes to इ; for example, कथयतु = कधेतु.

Final consonants disappear in Prakrit. Consonantal sandhi is largely absent.

In vowel sandhi, too, no sandhi takes place even when a medial sound has disappeared.

The dual number disappeared from nominal declension. Dative forms merged with the genitive. Words ending in consonants disappeared.

Verbal conjugation changed more extensively than nominal declension. Consonant-final verbal roots disappeared. Roots came to follow a single pattern of conjugation; the dual disappeared, and the diversity of forms

diminished. Ātmanepada forms largely disappeared, as did liṭ, liṅ and luṅ forms. Participial suffixes came into use for expressing the past. Of the verbal classes, all except the bhvādi and curādi classes disappeared.

In Śaurasenī, द्य, र्ज् and र्य् become ज्ज्.

Śaurasenī and Māhārāṣṭrī differ in the treatment of Sanskrit medial त: in Śaurasenī it becomes द, but in Māhārāṣṭrī it disappears. Thus Sanskrit जानाति = Śaurasenī जाणादि = Māhārāṣṭrī जाणाइ.

Sanskrit medial थ becomes ध in Śaurasenī but ह in Māhārāṣṭrī: Sanskrit अथ = Śaurasenī अध = Māhārāṣṭrī अह.

When ज्ञ occurs at the beginning of the second member of a compound, it becomes ञ्ञ in Māgadhī.

In Māgadhī, श, ष and स all become श; र becomes ल; and ज becomes य. The nominative singular of a-stem words takes ए. Thus दरिद्र = दलिद्द.

In Māgadhī, ज becomes य.

In Māgadhī, द्य, र्ज् and र्य् become य्य.

In Māgadhī, ण्य, न्य, ज्ञ and ञ्ज become ञ्ञ.

In Māgadhī, medial च्छ becomes श्च.

In Māgadhī, ष्क becomes स्क or श्क, ष्ट becomes स्ट or श्ट, ष्प becomes स्प, and ष्फ becomes स्फ.

In Māgadhī, र्थ becomes स्त.

The optative (vidhiliṅ) remained current in the Jain Prakrits—Ardhamāgadhī and Jain Māhārāṣṭrī—but largely disappeared from the other Prakrits.

Sanskrit तुम् becomes दुं in Śaurasenī and also in Māgadhī, but उं in Māhārāṣṭrī.

Besides Śaurasenī, Māgadhī and Māhārāṣṭrī, Paiśācī Prakrit is also mentioned. Guṇāḍhya's Bṛhatkathā was written in this Prakrit, but is no longer independently extant; it survives here and there in references and quotations. Paiśācī was a Prakrit of north-western India. According to the literature preserved in quotations, its characteristics were these: ण became न; र became ल; ल became र; voiced consonants became voiceless; intervocalic ल became ळ; intervocalic ष became श or स; ज्ञ became न्य;

and ण्य became ज्ज. It possessed both ātmanepada and parasmaipada forms.

A Prakrit Dhammapada has been recovered from Khotan in the north-west, written from right to left in the Kharoṣṭhī script; it uses all three sibilants, श, ष and स.

Broadly speaking, Prakrit displays a process of simplification in nominal and verbal forms, alongside consonant doubling, retroflexion, devoicing and voicing. The use of participles in place of finite tense forms also increased.

Prakrit and Pali

Did Vedic Sanskrit emerge from Prakrit, or Prakrit from Vedic Sanskrit? The popular narratives called nārāśaṃsī in the Vedas demonstrate that both traditions continued in parallel for a long time. Each influenced the other. Consider the Rigveda: what does the use of दूलभ for दुर्लभ (Rigveda 4.9.8) establish? What does पश्चा for पश्चात् (Atharvaveda 10.4.10) establish? And what does प्रतिसंहाय for प्रतिसन्धाय in the Gopatha Brāhmaṇa (2.4) establish? In Vedic times Sanskrit was not called "Sanskrit" as the name of a language. What we now call Prakrit acquired that form of identification, in relation to literary composition, after Pali.

Bharata discusses seven Prakrits in the Nāṭyaśāstra, while Vararuci discusses four.

Although Mahāvīra's teachings were expressed in Ardhamāgadhī Prakrit and the Buddha's in Māgadhī Prakrit, both were fundamentally languages of the people.

When people from different regions assembled, however, the Buddha instructed them to learn his teachings in their respective regional languages: "अनुजानामि भिक्खवे, सकायनिरुत्तियाबुद्धवचनं परियापुणितं"—that is, "Monks, I permit you to learn the Buddha's words in your own languages." Māgadhī, the language of the people, remained the principal element in the Buddha's teachings, but elements of other languages were also mixed into it; that language became Pali.

In Pali

The sounds ऋ, ऌ, ऐ, औ and अः do not occur, and अं is regarded as a consonant rather than a vowel.

The palatal श and retroflex ष do not occur either; only the dental स is present.

The Sanskrit consonant ळ occurs.

The Sanskrit conjunct consonants क्ष, त्र and ज्ञ do not occur.

ऋ changes to अ, इ, अ or इ, and इ or उ. वृ changes to रु.

ऌ changes to उ.

ऐ changes to इ or ए.

औ changes to उ or ओ.

Lengthening of a Sanskrit short vowel: सिंहः = सीहो.

Shortening of a Sanskrit long vowel: मुनीन्द्रः = मुनिन्दो.

Assimilation to a neighbouring vowel: निषण्णः = निसिन्नो.

Stress: मध्यमः = मज्झिमो.

Expansion: जयति = जेति.

Loss of a vowel: इति = ति.

ङ and ढ are also absent from Pali. स or छ is used for palatal श and retroflex ष; ळ is used for ङ and ल्ह for ढ.

क changes to य, as in लौकिकः = लोकियो, or to व, as in शुकः = सुवो.

Reordering also occurs: मशकः = मकसोः and करेणुः = कणेरु.

A consonant of the क series changes to one of the च series: कुन्दः = चुन्दो.

A consonant of the त series changes to one of the ट series: प्रथमः = पठमो.

ख undergoes fricativisation and becomes ह: प्रखरः = पहरो.

क becomes voiced ग: मूकः = मूगो.

ग becomes voiceless क: तडागम् = तळाकं.

झ loses aspiration and becomes ज: झल्लिका = जल्लिका.

प becomes aspirated फ: परश्ः = फरसु.

Consonants also disappear: पविसिष्यामि = पविस्सामि.

A weak conjunct consonant disappears: क्षत्रियः = खत्तियो.

ध्वजः = धजो.

Now observe the tendency towards simplification: गर्हा = गरहा; रत्नम् = रतनं.

Pali has three types of sandhi: vowel sandhi, consonant sandhi and anusvāra (niggahīta) sandhi.

Vowel sandhi: when one vowel is followed by another, either the preceding vowel or the following vowel may disappear; alternatively, neither disappears.

Consonant sandhi: when a consonant follows a short or long vowel, that vowel respectively becomes long or short.

Niggahīta sandhi: anusvāra (niggahīta) is inserted in some places and disappears in others. Examples: त + खणे = तंखणे; सं + रागो = सारागो.

Pali has only two numbers, singular and plural, and the case forms are listed as पठमा, दुतिया, ततिया, चतुत्थी, पञ्चमी, छट्ठी, सत्तमी and आलपन. Between 500 and 800 verbal roots are assigned to nine classes, with eight lakāras; āśīrliṅ and luṭ do not occur.

Compounds in Pali are formed in the same manner as in Sanskrit.

In Prakrit

The fundamental point, however, is that not every Prakrit word has a Sanskrit equivalent.

Literary Prakrit exists in several varieties.

In Paiśācī Prakrit, त is used for ट and ळ for ल.

In Ardhamāgadhī Prakrit, an independent medial क changes to ग, त or य. Between two vowels, प changes to व.

In Śaurasenī Prakrit, an independent त between two vowels changes to द, and थ changes to ह or ध.

In Māgadhī Prakrit, ल is used in place of र; य्य or ज्ज in place of य; and श in place of स and ष.

Prakrit has neither short nor long ऋ or ऌ, nor ऐ or औ. ण takes the place of न.

ऋ changes to अ, आ, ई, उ or रि.

ऌ changes to इलि.

ऐ changes to ए.

औ changes to उ.

Intervocalic क, ग, च, ज, त, द, य and व disappear, as in लोक = लोअ and लावण्य = लाअण्ण.

ख becomes ह: शाखा = शाहा.

An initial य becomes ज: यम = जम.

श and ष become स; क्ष becomes ख, छ or झ; ज्ञ becomes ण; त्व becomes च; थ्व becomes छ; द्व becomes ज; and ध्व becomes झ.

Sandhi follows the Sanskrit pattern. There are two numbers, singular and plural, and seven cases. As in Sanskrit, roots are divided into ten classes, but the forms of the tudādi class disappear. The past and future each have a single form.

Compounds in Prakrit are formed as in Sanskrit.

3. Avahaṭṭa

As Apabhraṃśa approached its final phase, Avahaṭṭa remained in use as a literary language from approximately the eleventh to the fourteenth century. Because of its proximity to Maithili it was also called "Maithil Apabhraṃśa," and it continued to be recognised as a variety of Apabhraṃśa.

Vidyapati himself calls the language of his Kīrtilatā and Kīrtipatākā Avahaṭṭa. Earlier, however, Paharāja had used this designation for a language in the Pāuakoso. Addahamāṇa refers to Avahaṭṭa in his Sandesarāsaka, as does Vaṃśīdhara in his commentary on the Prākṛta Paiṅgalam. Jyotirishwar writes in the Varṇaratnākara: "And what kind of bard? One acquainted with the substance of all six languages—Sanskrit, Prakrit, Avahaṭṭa, Paiśācī, Śaurasenī, and Māgadhī." In its later phase, Apabhraṃśa assumed the form of Avahaṭṭa in eastern India. Characteristics of Maithili—words generally ending in vowels, complex verbal forms (though without gender distinctions in these forms), and genitive forms of pronouns—were already beginning to appear in outline in Avahaṭṭa. In Vidyapati's Avahaṭṭa particularly, one encounters the i- and o-vowel spellings characteristic of Maithili, and the use of the fifth nasal consonants of the ka, ca, ṭa, ta, and pa series in place of anusvāra. Yet sometimes his Avahaṭṭa seems to be pure Maithili, while at other times it employs a larger vocabulary drawn from Prakrit, Persian, Gujarati-Saurashtri, Awadhi, and Kosali. This may explain how his Avahaṭṭa could become a language of broad, transregional reach—"viśva-kutūhalī," in Rājaśekhara's expression. Two Devanagari manuscripts were discovered in separate places, at Stambhatirtha in Gujarat and in the village of Asni in

Fatehpur district, Uttar Pradesh; a manuscript in Mithilakshar was found in Nepal. In the historical family classification of languages, Avahaṭṭa is termed "Maithil Apabhraṃśa" for these reasons, and its development from Māgadhī Prakrit is also discernible. Maithili's position can broadly be traced through the historical sequence Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit, Apabhraṃśa, and Avahaṭṭa. Although Avahaṭṭa is close to Maithili, it is also close to Śaurasenī Prakrit-Apabhraṃśa; its use of indigenous vocabulary, however, reveals many grammatical changes from Apabhraṃśa. Vidyapati's Kīrtilatā is written in Avahaṭṭa, but the Caryā songs and Varṇaratnākara, although earlier than Kīrtilatā, belong to Old Maithili and are also close to Avahaṭṭa. Dāmodara Paṇḍit's Ukti-Vyakti-Prakaraṇa likewise predates Kīrtilatā but provides models of Old Awadhi and Old Kosali and is close to Avahaṭṭa. It is also true that Vidyapati uses several varieties of Avahaṭṭa in Kīrtilatā and Kīrtipatākā. At first, the term was used as a synonym for Apabhraṃśa. Gradually, as the language shed the distinguishing characteristics of Apabhraṃśa and began to provide a basis for the grammatical features of modern Indian languages, especially Maithili, it acquired a distinct identity as Avahaṭṭa. Its principal grammatical characteristics are vowel combinations; compensatory lengthening; distinctive consonantal features; morphology relating to gender and number; uninflected forms; case-postpositions and case-endings; pronouns, adjectives, and pronominal adjectives; verbs, participles, imperatives, anterior verbal forms, compound verbs, and adverbs; features of vocabulary; stress on the preceding vowel; changes in vowel nasalisation and a tendency towards apparently unmotivated nasalisation; sequences of several vowels; loss of syllables; the use of root forms in place of postpositions; the abundance of pronouns; the development of verbal forms; and sentence construction.

Avahaṭṭa contains a substantial body of literature associated with Jainism, showing Śaurasenī influence. Its principal regions were Mānyakheṭa, Gujarat, Bengal, and Mithila. People associated with Jainism were concentrated particularly in Mānyakheṭa. Vajjālagga, a collection of aphoristic verses compiled by the Śvetāmbara monk Jayavallabha, shows the influence of Avahaṭṭa. Among related writings are Bharateśvara Bāhubalī Rāsa by Śālibhadra Sūri; Pañca Pāṇḍava Carita by another Śālibhadra Sūri; Sthūlibhadra Rāsa; Nemināth Phāgu by Jayaśekhara Sūri; and Solaha Kāraṇa Rāsa by Sakalakīrti. The oral poetic traditions also include the literature of the Buddhist siddhas, Ḍāk, Dharmamaṅgala poetry, Śūnyapurāṇa, Māṇikcandra Rājār Gān, and Lorikāin. After Avahaṭṭa, through Brajabuli, Rai Ramananda, Shankaradeva, and Chaitanyadeva reached the people by means of vernacular language. Avahaṭṭa influenced both Brajabuli and Maithili. The twelfth-century Ḍākārṇava was composed in Nepal, in the Mithilakshar script and the

Avahaṭṭa language. Works were composed in Avahaṭṭa during the Karnata and Oinwar dynasties in Mithila. Its use had already begun in siddha literature, the Buddhist Dohākośa and Caryā songs, and Jyotirishwar's Varṇaratnākara. Forms of Avahaṭṭa also occur in Muniram Singh's Pāhuḍa Dohā and texts of Buddhist Vajrayāna. Dāmodara Paṇḍit's Ukti-Vyakti-Prakaraṇa, a book for teaching Sanskrit, was composed in Avahaṭṭa. In the first half of the twelfth century, Addahamāṇa composed Sandesarāsaka, whose author himself identifies its language as Avahaṭṭa. The commentator on Prākṛta Paiṅgalam—a compilation on prosody whose compiler is unknown—also calls the language of that work Avahaṭṭa. Vidyapati's Kīrtilatā and Kīrtipatākā were likewise composed in Avahaṭṭa.

The grammatical distinction between Avahaṭṭa and Apabhraṃśa, and Avahaṭṭa's closeness to Maithili: its long compound vowels are ए, ऐ, ओ, and औ; scholars before Pāṇini called them sandhyakṣara. Sanskrit ऐ and औ became the sounds अइ and अउ, respectively, from which further vowels emerged. In languages following Sanskrit, especially medieval languages, the successive use of two or three vowels produced unusual features in both sound and writing. Modern languages needed to restore an earlier condition through greater use of consonants and tatsama vocabulary, so that pronunciation and writing might become easier. Vowels began to combine at the ends of verbs and in other grammatical positions. ऐ and औ became characteristic of Avahaṭṭa, as in टुट्टै = टूटै, गुण्णइ = गुणै, पइ = पै, रहइ = रहै, करउ = करौ, चअउर = चौरा, दुण्णउ = दूणौ, तउ = तौ, and आअउ = आऔ.

The sound ऋ began to be realised in three forms: र् + अ, र् + इ, and र् + उ. The middle form, रि (र् + इ), gradually became established. Thus अमृत = अमिअ, in which मृ becomes मि.

There were further changes among vowels. Lengthening of an initial vowel appears natural, as in आँचल = आँचर. The final आ of feminine words began to disappear, as in भिक्षा = भीख. Sandhi and elision increased in words containing successive vowels, as in धरित्री = धरती and उपआस = उपास.

The Apabhraṃśa अंधआर became अंधार through sandhi.

कज्ज became काज through lengthening; अंचल became आँचर through nasalisation.

Consonants largely remained the same, but ण became less frequent and ञ more frequent; the two new consonants ड़ and ढ़ emerged. क्ष = क् + ष

began to change into ष्ख. Alternation also developed between न and ल, as in नहिअ = लहिअ; even today both लोर and नोर are spoken in Maithili.

Nouns ending in उ remained, but अ, आ, इ, ई, ऊ, ऐ, and ओ also began to occur as noun endings. The tendency to form plurals by adding न्हि at the end increased, as in युवराजन्हि. The dual disappeared and the plural took its place; सव्वउं (सभ) also began to be used for this purpose.

Adjectives began to change their forms according to gender, and forms with omitted case-endings or without inflection became more common. Examples of changing adjectival forms are अइस, एत्ते, कतहु, पहिल, and चारु.

Alongside case-endings, forms such as सन, सउं, क, माझ, केर, and लागि began to be used.

Case-endings diminished in western Avahaṭṭa, but in eastern Avahaṭṭa the endings ए and हि performed a wide variety of grammatical functions.

Subject pronouns came to include हौ, तोञ, and सो; possessive or relational forms included मोञ, तुम्ह, and तिसु.

Verbal forms such as करउँ, करसि, and करथि came into use. Participial and related forms included पढ़न्ता, चलु, उपजु, गेल, भेल, कहल, मारल, चलल, करहुं, कहसि, जाहि, and पावथि.

Compound tenses, such as आवत्त हुअ, began to be used.

In the eastern future-tense formation, व was used; in the western formation, ह.

Adverbs such as जनु, नहु, बिनु, and अबस came into use.

Stress fell on the preceding vowel, as in अक्खर = आखर.

The number of pronouns increased.

As verbal forms developed, the use of participles in the present tense increased.

Word order within the sentence now became more firmly determined: broadly, the subject came first, followed by the object, with the verb at the end.

Compound tense constructions also began to appear.

A strong tendency towards lengthening the vowel of a word's first syllable is found in Avahaṭṭa; the final आ of feminine words began to disappear. Nasalised words increased in number. Nouns retained two numbers, but singular forms also came to be employed for plurals. Most nominal stems ended in vowels, including अ. Postpositions began to replace inflectional endings. For the ablative, हुंते and सउँ came into use, and for the locative, माँझ and उप्परि. At times a candrabindu alone served to express both the ablative and the locative. The ending हिं likewise served several cases, while ए came to express the accusative, instrumental, and locative. A comparable simplification of nouns occurred among pronouns. Verbal formation became simpler through more frequent use of participles and the growth of compound verbs. The past tense also came to be formed with ल and the future with व, as in थाकल and पढ़ब, forms subsequently adopted in Maithili.

Stress on the preceding vowel and compensatory vowel lengthening are principal characteristics of Avahaṭṭa. The Apabhraṃśa words अक्खर, ठक्कुर, and नच्चइ became आखर, ठाकुर, and नाचइ, respectively. Changes in the nasalisation of vowels altered the older rules. Previously, anusvāra was absent before stop consonants; the fifth letters of the क, च, ट, त, and प series were employed in conjuncts instead. Anusvāra was used exceptionally before the consonants from य to ह. In addition to stress on the preceding vowel and compensatory lengthening, anusvāra began to occur with stress on the vowel before a conjunct consonant, as in ऊसास /आंग /आँकुस / आँचर /काँट /लाँघि /पाँच /चाँद /आँगन /.

Respectively,

these replaced उस्सास /अंग /अंकुस /अंचल /कण्टक /लघ् /पंच /चन्द्र / अंगण /. Alongside compensatory vowel lengthening, the length or weight of anusvāra was reduced, and the tendency towards apparently unmotivated nasalisation found in modern Maithili began, as in कज्ज = काँज, कच्चु: = काँच, भग्ग = भाँग, and ओष्ठ = ओंदिम.

Loss of syllables: contraction or elision produced अन्धकार = अन्हार, देवकुल = देउर, देवगृह = देवहा, कोट्टशीर्ष = कोसीस, उपवास = उपास, उत्तिष्ठ = उँट, सहकार = सहार, स्वर्णकार = सोनार, सुन्नाअर = सुन्नार, and सहयार = साहार.

Increased use of postpositions: postpositions inherited from Apabhraṃśa became still more frequent during the Avahaṭṭa period. For example:

Nominative (agent): एन्ने.

Instrumental: सन, सउं.

Dative: लागि, लग्गि, लागे, प्रति, कारण.

Ablative: सओ, हुत, हुते, हुंति, सिउ.

Genitive: केर, कर, के, करेउ, कइ, क.

Locative: माझ, ऊपर, माँझ, भीतर, माहि.

Proliferation of pronouns: Kīrtilatā uses जेन्ने; elsewhere one finds forms such as मोर, मेरहु, तोरा, तोहार, तोहर, and तोरा. Relative pronouns included जओन, जेन्ने, जस, जसु, and जे; interrogatives included केहु and कोए; indefinites, कोइ and केहु; and reflexives, अपन, अपनेहु, and निअ.

The development of verb forms through participles: participial usage increased, including the use of past participles for the present, sometimes also in their full forms.

Present participial forms included पढ़न्ता, कहन्ता, and आवन्ता; future forms included करहुं and करिहि; and past participial forms included चलु and लागु.

The modern ending ता developed from अन्त, whose use increased. Compound verbs began to appear, such as forming खाइले by adding ले; पार came into use to indicate capacity, while चाह and लागु served to indicate the beginning of an action.

4. Maithili

In the historical classification of language families, Avahaṭṭa is called "Maithil Apabhraṃśa" for these reasons, and its development from Māgadhī Prakrit can also be observed. Although close to Maithili, Avahaṭṭa is also related to Śaurasenī Prakrit-Apabhraṃśa; because of its indigenous vocabulary, however, it displays many grammatical changes from Apabhraṃśa. Vidyapati's Kīrtilatā is in Avahaṭṭa, but the Caryā songs and Varṇaratnākara, although earlier than Kīrtilatā, are in Old Maithili and also close to Avahaṭṭa. Within the Indo-European family, the position of Maithili may be traced, broadly speaking, through the historical succession Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit, Apabhraṃśa, and Avahaṭṭa.

Sounds: to pronounce dental न, the tongue should touch the teeth, as in नाम; to pronounce retroflex ण, it should touch the roof of the mouth in the retroflex region, as in गणेश. Failure to do so constitutes a

pronunciation error. For palatal श the tongue touches the palate, for ष the retroflex region, and for dental स the teeth. Try pronouncing निशाँ, सभ, and शोषण. In Maithili, ष is also pronounced like ख, as in Vedic Sanskrit, for example in वर्षा and दोष. In many contexts य is pronounced like ज and ण like ड़; thus संयोग and गणेश may be pronounced संजोग and गड़ेस. Maithili also pronounces व as ब, श as स, and य as ज.

Similarly, the short इ in Maithili is often pronounced before the consonant, because in both Devanagari and Mithilakshar its sign is written before that consonant and ought also to be pronounced before it. Hindi, by contrast, is said to pronounce it incorrectly: although written before the letter, the vowel is spoken after it. Through the influence of that system of education, we too are adopting the same defective pronunciation.

पानि – पाइन – पैन.

अछि – अ इ छ – ऐछ.

छथि – छ इ थ – छैथ.

पहुँचि – प हुँ इ च.

The question then arises: what is wrong with writing छैथ for छथि? The difficulty is that in many parts of Mithila people also say छथि, छथी, पानि, पानी, पहुँचि, and पहुँची. Writing पानि, रहथि, and पहुँचि therefore represents all the regions.

There are vowel signs for अ, आ, इ, ई, ए, ऐ, ओ, औ, अं, अः, and ऋ. Yet ई, ऐ, ओ, औ, अं, अः, and ऋ are incorrectly used and pronounced as conjunct sounds: for example, pronouncing ऋ as री. Similarly, देखिऔ is inappropriate in place of देखियौ, while देखिये is inappropriate in place of देखिऐ. The inherent अ combines with consonants from क् to ह् to form क through ह. A tendency has nevertheless grown to pronounce the endings of words as if they carried a halant. When we pronounce the final ज् in मनोज, however, older speakers can still be heard saying मनोजऽ: they are actually pronouncing ज् with its inherent अ, that is, ज.

The conjunct ज्ञ consists of ज् and ञ, but it is incorrectly pronounced ग्य. Likewise, क्ष is composed of क् and ष, yet is pronounced छ. The combination of श् and र makes श्र (as in श्रमिक), whereas स् and र make स्र (as in मिस्र). त्र is त + र.

Write कैं, सँ, and पर joined to the preceding word, but keep तँ, के, and कऽ separate. Where सँ occurs twice, attach the first and separate the second. Attach टा immediately after numerals, but separate it elsewhere: thus छहटा, but सभ टा. Write ६अ म and सातम, not छठम and सातम. Use बला in घरबला, but वाली in घरवाली.

रहए – रहै; but सकैए (pronounced सकै-ए).

Sometimes, however, रहए and रहै also differ in meaning. For example, "He had experience of parking in that very place." On inquiry it emerged that the driver, named Dhundhun, used to work in a parking area at Connaught Place.

The same applies to छलै and छलए. The latter can also be pronounced छल-ए.

संयोगने – pronounced संजोगने.

कैं /के /कऽ.

केर – क (do not use केर).

क, as in रामक: write रामक; it can also be pronounced राम के or राम कऽ.

सँ – सऽ.

Candrabindu and anusvāra: anusvāra involves articulation as far back as the throat, whereas candrabindu does not. Candrabindu is also pronounced with a slight e-like element, as in रामसँ (pronounced राम सऽ) and रामकैं (also pronounced राम कऽ or राम के).

कैं, as in रामकैं, corresponds to Hindi को: राम को = रामकैं.

क, as in रामक, corresponds to Hindi का: राम का = रामक.

कऽ, as in जा कऽ, corresponds to Hindi कर: जा कर = जा कऽ.

सँ corresponds to Hindi से: राम से = रामसँ.

Use of सऽ, तऽ, त, and केर is undesirable.

के may have another meaning, as in के कहलक? ("Who said it?").

नञि, नहि, नै, नइ, नँइ, and नइँ are all pronounced नै.

अ sometimes becomes ओ, as in मन = मोन and वन = बोन (rounded articulation).

अ sometimes becomes आ, as in फंदा = फान and चन्द्र = चान (stress).

घर = घऽर (pronunciation; stress).

बुद्ध = बुद्धऽ (pronunciation; stress).

घमसान = घमऽसान (the short vowel before the long vowel is distinctly pronounced; stress).

When आ precedes इ, the resulting pronunciation is ऐ, as in पानि = पैन. Yet पानी and पानि are pronounced in different regions, so the spellings पानि and आगि remain appropriate.

आ sometimes becomes अ, as in काका = कक्का.

इ sometimes becomes ओ, as in रिवाज = रेबाज.

ऋ sometimes becomes इ, ई, or ऊ, as in कृष्ण = किसुन, पृष्ठ = पीठ, and वृद्ध = बूढ.

At the end of a word, इ is written instead of ई.

ऋ sometimes becomes अ, as in वृषभ = बसहा and अहृदी = अहदी.

उ sometimes becomes ओ, as in दुकान = दोकान.

ऊ sometimes becomes ओ, as in मूल्य = मोल.

अए sometimes becomes ए, as in कएलनि = केलनि.

ऐ sometimes becomes अइ or अए, as in भैया = भइया and पैर = पएर.

आ + ओ sometimes becomes औ, as in गमाओल = गमौल.

क sometimes becomes ख or ग, as in पुष्करि = पोखरि and भक्त = भगत.

ष, when at the beginning or end of a word, sometimes becomes ख, as in षष्ठी = खष्ठी and भेष-भूषा = भेख-भूखा.

क्ष sometimes becomes ख, as in क्षीर = खीर.

ज्ञ sometimes becomes ग, as in यज्ञ = जाग.

ग sometimes becomes घ, as in गर्ग = घाघ.

त्य sometimes becomes च, as in सत्य = साँच.

त्स्य sometimes becomes छ, as in मत्स्य = माँछ.

Initial य sometimes becomes ज, as in यम = जम.

द्य sometimes becomes ज, as in विद्युत = बिजुली.

ध्य sometimes becomes झ, as in वंध्या = बाँझ.

त sometimes becomes ट, as in कर्तन = काटब.

न्थ sometimes becomes ठ, as in ग्रन्थि = गेंठ.

द sometimes becomes ड, as in दण्ड = डाँट.

त sometimes disappears, as in जाइत = जाइ.

स्त sometimes becomes थ, as in प्रस्तर = पाथर.

द sometimes becomes ड, as in दाह = डाह.

Final ध sometimes becomes दह, as in गधा = गदहा.

ल sometimes becomes न, and न sometimes becomes ल, as in नोर = लोर.

प sometimes becomes फ, as in पाश = फाँस.

फ sometimes becomes प and ह, as in बेवकूफ = बेकूफ.

ब sometimes becomes म, as in शैबाल = सेमार.

म्भ sometimes becomes म, as in खम्भा = खमहा.

म्ब sometimes becomes म, as in कम्बल = कम्मल.

ल sometimes becomes र, as in हल = हर.

व sometimes becomes भ, as in वाष्प = भाप.

Final ह sometimes disappears, as in गेलाह = गेला.

Use त्व instead of त्त्व, as in महत्वपूर्ण (not महत्त्वपूर्ण). A three-letter conjunct is justified only where it changes meaning. Write सम्पति, pronounced स म्प इ त, rather than सम्पत्ति, because the latter is difficult to pronounce correctly; but write सर्वोत्तम, not सर्वोतम.

Attach मे, कैं, सँ, and पर to the preceding word; write तँ, कऽ, धऽ, and दऽ separately. Where two or more case markers occur together, attach only the first.

एकटा, दूटा; but कैक टा.

Use the bikārī sign only at the end of a word, not unnecessarily in the middle. Do not use it after a final आ or after final अ, as in दिअ and आ.

Replacing the bikārī sign (ऽ, known in Sanskrit as avagraha and in Bengali as japhalā) with an apostrophe is inappropriate and merely signals a technical deficiency in the font. The Sanskrit form of bikārī is called avagraha. It may disappear in spelling as well as pronunciation, and in pronunciation it does disappear. Yet the apostrophe in English marks the possessive case, while in French expressions such as raison d'être it joins rather than separates sounds: the expression is pronounced approximately "raison detre." Thus replacing bikārī with an apostrophe is technically inappropriate as well.

In Maithili quantitative stress, a stressed short vowel becomes long. If a word contains a long vowel, stress falls upon it; if there is no long vowel, stress falls on the penultimate vowel. Where two long vowels occur consecutively, the penultimate long vowel bears the stress: पा'नि, ओसा'रा. Emphatic stress also occurs when particular emphasis is given to an utterance, as in अपन = अप्पन. All vowels preceding the stressed vowel become short.

Distinctive Features of Maithili Pronunciation and Writing

1. The fifth consonants and anusvāra: the fifth consonants of the five series are ङ, ञ, ण, न, and म. According to the Sanskrit system, the fifth consonant of the relevant series appears before the corresponding consonant. For example:

अङ्क (ङ् occurs because the following consonant belongs to the क series).

पञ्च (ञ् occurs because the following consonant belongs to the च series).

खण्ड (ण् occurs because the following consonant belongs to the ट series).

सन्धि (न् occurs because the following consonant belongs to the त series).

खम्भ (म् occurs because the following consonant belongs to the प series).

The above practice is less frequently observed in Maithili. Anusvāra is used in place of the fifth consonant in most positions: अंक, पंच, खंड, संधि, खंभ, and so on. The grammarian Pandit Govind Jha maintains that anusvāra should be written before the क, च, and ट series, while the fifth consonants themselves should be written before the त and प series; thus अंक, चंचल, अंडा, अन्त, and कम्पन. Modern writers influenced by Hindi, however, do

not accept this distinction; they also write अंत and कंपन instead of अन्त and कम्पन.

The newer practice is certainly convenient, since it saves time and space. Yet when the tiny dot of anusvāra is unclear in handwriting or print, the meaning can sometimes be distorted. Its use also raises the possibility of errors in pronunciation. It is therefore appropriate to use the fifth consonants of the relevant series with consonants from क through the प series. There appears to be no dispute about the use of anusvāra with letters from य through ज्ञ.

2. ढ and ढ़: ढ़ is pronounced approximately like "र् ह." Accordingly, ढ़ should be written only where that pronunciation occurs; elsewhere ढ should be written. For example:

ढ: ढाकी, ढेकी, ढीठ, ढेउआ, ढङ्ग, ढेरी, ढाकनि, ढाठ, and so on.

ढ़: पढ़ाइ, बढ़ब, गढ़ब, मढ़ब, बुढ़बा, साँढ़, गाढ़, रीढ़, चाँढ़, सीढ़ी, पीढ़ी, and so on.

These words show that ढ generally occurs at the beginning of a word, while ढ़ appears in the middle or at the end. The same principle applies to ड and ड़.

3. व and ब: in Maithili the letter व is pronounced ब, but it should not therefore be written as ब. The pronunciations बैद्यनाथ, बिद्या, नब, देबता, बिष्णु, बंश, and बन्दना should respectively be written वैद्यनाथ, विद्या, नव, देवता, विष्णु, वंश, and वन्दना. Generally, ओ is used to convey the sound of व, as in ओकील and ओजह.

4. य and ज: in some places य is pronounced like ज, but should not be written ज. Words pronounced यज्ञ, जदि, जमुना, जुग, जाबत, जोगी, जदु, and जम should respectively be written यज्ञ, यदि, यमुना, युग, यावत, योगी, यदु, and यम.

5. ए and य: both ए and य are used in Maithili spelling.

Older spellings: कएल, जाए, होएत, माए, भाए, गाए, and so on.

Newer spellings: कयल, जाय, होयत, माय, भाय, गाय, and so on.

At the beginning of a word, ए normally occurs, as in एहि, एना, एकर, and एहन. These should not be replaced with यहि, यना, यकर, or यहन.

Nevertheless, certain Maithili-speaking communities, including some Tharu groups, pronounce initial ए as य.

For the use of ए and य, it is considered appropriate in this book to follow the older convention. Neither is intrinsically easier or harder to write; the pronunciation of Maithili speakers in general is closer to ए than to य. The occasional writing of words such as कएल and हएब as कैल and हैब further supports the suitability of ए.

6. हि and हु, and e- and o-vowel endings: in the older Maithili writing tradition, हि or हु is added to a word for emphasis, as in हुनकहि, अपनहु, ओकरहु, तत्कालहि, चोट्टहि, and आनहु. Modern usage, however, often substitutes an e-ending for हि and an o-ending for हु: हुनके, अपनो, तत्काले, चोट्टे, आनो, and so on.

7. ष and ख: in Maithili, ष is usually pronounced ख, as in षड्यन्त्र (खड़यन्त्र), षोडशी (खोड़शी), षट्कोण (खटकोण), वृषेश (वृखेश), and सन्तोष (सन्तोख).

8. Loss of sounds: a sound disappears from a word under the following conditions.

(a) The य or ए of the verbal suffix अय is lost. The preceding अ is lengthened in pronunciation, and a mark of elision, or bikārī (’ / ऽ), is placed after it. For example:

Full forms: पढ़ए (पढ़य) गेलाह; कए (कय) लेल; उठए (उठय) पड़तौक.

Contracted forms: पढ़’ गेलाह; कऽ लेल; उठ’ पड़तौक.

Also written: पढ़ऽ गेलाह; कऽ लेल; उठऽ पड़तौक.

(b) The य (ए) of the anterior participial suffix आय (आए) disappears, but no bikārī mark is added. For example:

Full forms: खाए (य) गेल; पठाय (ए) देब; नहाए (य) अएलाह.

Contracted forms: खा गेल; पठा देब; नहा अएलाह.

(c) The sound इ of the feminine suffix इ is lost in verbs, nouns, and adjectives alike. For example:

Full form: दोसरि मालिनि चलि गेलि.

Contracted form: दोसर मालिन चलि गेल.

(d) The final त of a present participle disappears. For example:

Full forms: पढ़ैत अछि; बजैत अछि; गबैत अछि.

Contracted forms: पढ़ै अछि; बजै अछि; गबै अछि.

(e) The endings इक, उक, ऐक, and हीक disappear from verbal forms. For example:

Full forms: छियौक; छियैक; छहीक; छौक; छैक; अबितैक; होइक.

Contracted forms: छियौ; छियै; छही; छौ; छै; अबितै; होइ.

(f) The verbal suffixes न्ह, हु, and the ह sound disappear. For example:

Full forms: छन्हि; कहलन्हि; कहलहुँ; गेलह; नहि.

Contracted forms: छनि; कहलनि; कहलौं; गेलऽ; नइ; नञि; नै.

9. Transposition of sounds: certain vowel sounds shift from one position to another, particularly the short इ and उ. When these vowels occur in the middle or at the end of a word that has undergone Maithilisation, their sound moves forward by one letter: शनि (शइन), पानि (पाइन), दालि (दाइल), माटि (माइट), काछु (काउछ), मासु (माउस), and so on. This rule does not apply to tatsama words: रश्मि cannot be pronounced रइश्म, nor सुधांशु as सुधाउंस.

10. Use of halant (्): generally, Maithili has little need for the halant because the inherent final अ is not pronounced. In tatsama words taken into Maithili unchanged from Sanskrit, however, the halant is used.

11. Words current in Maithili literature from ancient times to the present are generally written in their established spellings. Examples of acceptable forms, followed by unacceptable forms, are:

Acceptable: एखन; ठाम; जकर, तकर; तनिकर; अछि.

Unacceptable: अखन, अखनि, एखेन, अखनी; ठिमा, ठिना, ठमा; जेकर, तेकर; तिनकर (acceptable as an alternative); ऐछ, अहि, ए.

12. The following three sets of forms may be adopted as alternatives: भऽ गेल /भय गेल /भए गेल; जा रहल अछि /जाय रहल अछि /जाए रहल अछि; कर' गेलाह /करय गेलाह /करए गेलाह.

13. न may be written instead of the न्ह sound of Old Maithili: कहलनि or कहलन्हि.

14. ऐ and औ are written where the pronunciation is distinctly like अइ and अउ, as in देखैत, छलैक, बौआ, and छौक.

15. The following Maithili words are to be used in these forms: जैह, सैह, इएह, ओऐह, लैह, and दैह.

16. Omission of इ in a word ending in short इ is generally unacceptable: acceptable forms include देखि आबह and मालिनि गेलि (in reference to persons).

17. The independent short ए or य in quotations from Old Maithili is retained as in the original, but in modern usage either ए or य may be used: कयल /कएल, अयलाह /अएलाह, जाय /जाए.

18. The य sound that arises spontaneously between two vowels in pronunciation may optionally be represented in writing: धीआ /धीया, अढ़ैआ /अढ़ैया, विआह /बियाह.

19. The independent nasalised vowel may, wherever possible, be represented by ञ or by a nasalised vowel: मैञा /मैआँ, कनिञा /कनिआँ, किरतनिञा /किरतनिआँ.

20. Acceptable case forms are हाथकेँ, हाथसँ, हाथेँ, हाथक, and हाथमे. Anusvāra is to be wholly avoided in मे. केर may be retained as an alternative to कऽ.

21. The indeclinables कय or कए may optionally follow an anterior verbal form, as in देखि कय or देखि कए.

22. माङ and भाङ may be written in place of माँग and भाँग, and so on.

23. Anusvāra is not written in place of half न or half म; for ease of printing it may, however, replace half ङ, ञ, or ण: अङ्क /अंक, अञ्चल /अंचल, कण्ठ /कंठ.

24. The halant mark is normally used, but the अ-ending is employed with an inflectional suffix: श्रीमान्, but श्रीमानक.

25. All single case markers are attached to the word, not separated from it. In compound inflections they are written separately, as in घर परक.

26. Nasalisation is indicated by candrabindu, but for ease of printing, anusvāra may be substituted where the vowel sign is difficult, as in हिं instead of हिँ.

27. The full stop is represented by the danda (।).

28. Compounds are written together or joined by a hyphen, never as separate words.

29. The bikārī (ऽ)—called avagraha in Sanskrit and japhalā in Bengali—is not used in लिअ and दिअ.

30. Numerals are written in Devanagari forms.

31. New symbols should be devised for certain sounds. Until they are created, these two sounds may continue to be expressed as अय /आय /अए /आए /आओ /अओ, or by ऐ or औ.

Distinctive Features of Maithili Grammar: Maithili has continued to change through the eras of the Buddhist siddha masters, the Karnata and Oinwar dynasties, the Malla dynasty, medieval Maithili, and the so-called standard of modern Maithili, with its eastern, western, northern, and southern variations. Maithili grammar incorporates the characteristics of all these phases.

All Maithili words end in vowels, and the sounds अ, the rounded अ, ए, य, ऐ, यै, ओ, and औ are distinctly pronounced. The genitive employs सँ, क, and केर (the last occurring more often in poetry). Nominal forms are fewer and simpler: the plural can be made by adding सभ, for instance. Verb-root forms, however, are more numerous. The verb changes according to respectful and non-respectful address. In Maithili, verbal forms are determined by the subject and also by another noun or pronoun in the sentence related to the subject. Verbs change according to grammatical person. The suffix ब forms not only the future tense but also verbal nouns. The use of ल in participial forms such as कहल and गेल is a distinctive feature of Maithili.

Stress may fall on different syllables within Maithili words. Case-inflected forms do not ordinarily produce an oblique stem, as in गामक; the genitive provides an exception, as in साँझ–साँझुक. Oblique forms also occur among verbal nouns.

Nouns: a name or nominal expression has three degrees—small, large, and larger still—illustrated by मनोज्, मनोज, and मनोजबा.

Gender: the system of gender is simple. Inanimate nouns have become masculine. A noun does not change its form according to gender, but an adjective or verb may do so.

Number: nouns do not change their forms according to number; number is expressed by adding words such as लोकनि or रास. हम is singular and हमसभ plural.

Inflectional endings: instrumental -ए-, as in काजे; locative -आँ-हि-, as in परुकाँ and चोट्टहि.

Cases: nominative—unmarked; accusative—केँ; instrumental—सँ; dative —लए; ablative—सँ; genitive—क, or केर (in poetry); locative—मे.

Pronouns, first person: हम, हमे.

Second person: तूँ, तौं, अहाँ, अपने, ई.

Third-person and other pronominal forms: ताहि, तकरा, तकर, हुनका, हुनि, ओकरा, हुनकर, ओकर, हिनका, एकर, हिनकर, जाहि, जकरा, जकर, के, की, ककरा, अपन, कोन, किछु, केदन, केहनदन, कोनादन, एतबा, कतबा, ततबा, ततेक.

Adverbs: एतए, कहाँ, कखन, जखन, जाबे, ताबे, आबे, आब, जहिआ, तहिआ, कहिआ, जेना, तेना, एम्हर, ओम्हर, जेम्हर, तेम्हर, भर (as in दक्षिणभर). Temporal forms include आइ, काल्हि, परसू, लगले, परुकाँ; locative forms include आगाँ and पाछाँ; manner expressions include भने and कने-मने; conjunctions include मुदा and आर; vocatives include रौ and हौ; connective expressions include ईह and छी; and emphatic particles include -ए. There are also forms such as नहि and भरिसक, among various other adverbs and particles.

Prefixes: अ, अन, अध, अब, दु, नि, भरि, कम, ब, बद, बे, सर.

Suffixes: अक्कड़, अंत, इल, आइन, आइ, आउ, आकू, आन, आना, आप, आयत, आर, इन, बाह, आरि, आरी, आहु, औन, इअल, इआ, ई, गर, ऐत, ओड़, ओला, औटी, औती, ओना, औबिल, क, त, औत, आइ, बान, म, बला, हार, हा, ई, कार, बाह, आनी, खाना, खोर, गरी, ची, बाज.

Adjectives: these change according to respect and gender. सिलेबी, गोल, and चर्की are used of cows and oxen, and an adjective may therefore identify the animal being described. Compare पढ़ल (masculine) and पढ़लि (feminine), or मझिला छौड़ा and माँझिल भाइ (respectful form).

Verbs: Maithili verbs do not distinguish number, but they do distinguish grammatical person, and their form also changes to express respect. Finite verbs do not mark gender, whereas participles do change according to

gender. The verb changes in relation to the case or participant involved. Thus the verbal form itself can disclose whether the subject is respected, which grammatical person the object belongs to, and whether that object is respected. There are four verbal types: dying oneself—मरब (मरैत अछि); killing—मारब (मारैत अछि); causing someone else to kill—मरबाएब (मरबैत अछि); and arranging for someone to be killed through another person—मरबबैत अछि.

Verbal roots: Dinbandhu Jha collected approximately 1,225 Maithili roots, only somewhat fewer than the 2,000 roots in Pāṇini's inventory. These 1,225 roots alone are sufficient to sustain the independent existence of the Maithili language. Some examples follow.

छक—to be defeated without resistance in another activity: रूपलाल फुल तोड़बामे सोनेलालसँ छकलाह—Rup Lal was beaten by Sone Lal in picking flowers.

ठक—to cheat or deceive: ठक बुड़िबककेँ ठकैत अछि—a cheat misleads a foolish person in order to take away his belongings.

डक—to diffuse a powerful characteristic smell: हौगु डकैत अछि—asafoetida spreads its pungent odour.

ढक—to praise oneself extravagantly and falsely: जयलाल ढकैत छथि—Jaylal speaks in exaggerated, untruthful praise of himself.

बक—to talk excessively about things not worth hearing: जयलाल बकैत छथि—Jaylal says many things that are not worth listening to.

मक—to gambol or run about joyfully, especially of an animal: बाछा मकैत अछि—the calf runs playfully from one side to another.

In the Sundarakāṇḍa, Vālmīki uses the expression "mānuṣīm iha saṃskṛtām," making Hanuman speak of his knowledge of both Sanskrit and the human language. Jyotirishwar writes in the Varṇaratnākara: "And what kind of bard? One acquainted with the substance of all six languages —Sanskrit, Prakrit, Avahaṭṭa, Paiśācī, Śaurasenī, and Māgadhī." Jyotirishwar also discusses seven "sub-languages." There were several varieties of Prakrit. Māgadhī Prakrit contributed to the development of Maithili and other languages of eastern India. Jain religious texts were written in Ardhamāgadhī, while Buddhist religious texts were written in Pali. Kālidāsa's Sanskrit plays employed Apabhraṃśa in addition to Sanskrit for characters outside the elite, while the language of the Caryāpada was also Apabhraṃśa mixed with Māgadhī. It is also apparent that Maithili and other modern Indo-Aryan languages developed from

other Prakrit varieties. In its later phase, Apabhraṃśa took the form of Avahaṭṭa in eastern India. The outlines of features characteristic of Maithili—vowel-final words, complicated verbal inflection (without gender distinctions), and the genitive forms of pronouns—had already begun to be visible in Avahaṭṭa.

33. Acting Workshop

Abstract

[*Acting Workshop (for Theatre and Film): A Prelude to the Videha Theatre (and Film) Festival, 2012.*] *This article is based on forty lectures, translated into Sanskrit, which I delivered over three months to trainee teachers selected for primary schools in Odisha at the Sri Aurobindo Ashram. I learned more from them than I taught them.*

Keywords: acting · workshop · literary criticism · Maithili

[Acting Workshop (for Theatre and Film): A Prelude to the Videha Theatre (and Film) Festival, 2012]

(This article is based on forty lectures, translated into Sanskrit, which I delivered over three months to trainee teachers selected for primary schools in Odisha at the Sri Aurobindo Ashram. I learned more from them than I taught them. They now teach in remote parts of Odisha. This article is dedicated to them.—Gajendra Thakur)

1

2

What is acting? Children spread their things around and remain engaged in one activity or another. My daughter makes imaginary tea and offers it to me. I pretend to sip it, little by little. Then she brings real soup. I am working and, without even turning my face, pretend to sip the tea; but my daughter says, "This is real." My illusion is broken, and I return to the real world.

Children learn through drama and attempt to understand people and their surroundings.

Drama performed at temple festivals and in royal palaces subsequently acquired an independent existence, and its application to teaching other subjects also began. The participation of specialists from those subjects became necessary. Drama is both an independent subject and a means of practical application. Traditional theatre will become part of theatrical history through its connection with professional drama, through exemplary performances and stage decoration, and through the actual staging of plays. Before that, however, students must acquire elementary theatrical knowledge and develop the habit of reading plays. While reading, they must also analyse plays from the perspectives of stage management and acting.

Information about political, social and cultural developments must be supplied in relation to the production concerned. Alongside Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, familiarity with the plays of Kālidāsa, Bhāsa and Śūdraka is essential.

Those associated with theatre should know and have experience of both the Little Tradition and the Great Tradition.

If children engage with drama and theatre, they will become responsible citizens, economically self-reliant and active participants in civic life.

2

Chaitanya Mahaprabhu used the vīthī form of performance, combining music and dance within the jātrā tradition, to spread his message.

The Nāṭyaśāstra states that drama originated in the festival of Indra's banner. It associates two kinds of dramatic presentation with (1) the Churning of the Ocean of Nectar and (2) Śiva's Burning of Tripura. Bharata knew approximately ten such types of dramatic scenes or representations—the daśarūpaka—in which dance, music and acting were included; in addition to these ten forms, there were songs intended for listening.

In the fifth century BCE, Pāṇini mentions Śilālin and Kṛśāśva, who had compiled the Naṭasūtras. Naṭa means an actor and raṅga means a stage. Bharata, Śilālin and Kṛśāśva are also used as corresponding names for the actor.

Maithili drama, which until now has been connected principally with dance and music and only marginally with painting and handicrafts, should also be brought into contact with physics, biology, history, geography and literature.

3

Teach children how to hold and operate different tools, how to grease them and keep them safe. Teach them how to clean a house, the difference between a clean and a disorderly home, and which things need frequent cleaning and which do not. Dolls can be made from wire, torn or old fabric, broken bangles and ornaments, old saris, cotton and similar materials; faces, eyes and other features can be represented using these. Use plastic for the skin of the body, or apply layers of colour to fabric. Make hair from wool and similar materials; to represent heroes and warriors, use wooden swords and large shoes; then teach the making of labourer dolls and other figures. The aim is to construct characters of every kind.

Teach, through imaginary action, how to tether cattle, milk them, avoid being kicked, set curd, churn lassi, and coordinate the eyes and hands. Introduce games such as kariyā jhummari and others.

Teach the making of paper boats and aeroplanes and the drawing of pictures. Theatre is a means of understanding written material and comprehending a subject.

Acting: walking itself takes many forms. Teach children and adult actors to walk hurriedly; to walk while lifting a load or a spade; to move with enthusiasm or in sorrow; to walk wearily, stumbling with exhaustion; to limp; to follow the crowd like sheep; to march shouting slogans; and to walk with two or three companions. Touch: touching hot or cold things, hard or soft objects, and then responding to them. There is also a need to display fear, attachment, tamas, modesty, the refusal to act, stubbornness, sadness and laughter, from a giggle to a laugh with the mouth closed; to look with happiness or surprise; and to react to different kinds of scenes. Attend to the activities of markets, schools, homes and assemblies; memory, vocabulary, concentration, personality, ability, ideology, self-respect, desire, bodily confidence and enthusiasm; discussions of women and men, psychology, poetry, prose, songs, stories and riddles; and their memorisation and recitation. Give children experience of bodily movement, dance, music, hand gestures and group exercise, and of imaginary situations such as a gust of wind entering a room, a window opening, or something falling upon the head. Make them experience surroundings, motion, form, size and shape. Practise playing personalities different from their own; the relationship between sound and image and their simultaneous repetition; staging both real and imaginary situations; conversation on a subject; topics from books, newspapers and documentary films; and topical issues. Forced memorisation is wrong, whereas remembering by repeated listening is good. For games, divide children into two teams and have them act; one group may pretend to sleep while another wakes it by imitating a nāṛhiyā or a crow. Practise the collective recitation of verses and similar exercises.

In workshops, if someone finds a task difficult, ask another person to help. When someone offers a suggestion, discuss it together and think collectively. Allocate work according to ability, and praise those who perform it well. Teach courteous and truthful speech. Teach participants to wait their turn before speaking, follow the director's instructions, share materials and use them cooperatively. Develop an awareness of duty and assign responsibilities. Encourage participation in collective work and other social conduct. Teach conversation and acting through observation and listening, through imitation, through repetition, and through praise and encouragement. Maintain an atmosphere of pleasure and amusement.

Avoid long lectures: examples, practice and encouragement work better than speeches. Avoid punishment and comparisons between children. Do not diminish any child in another child's eyes. Arrange meetings with people outside the group. Celebrate festivals together and go on outings together. Show affection, smile, nod in encouragement, pat a child on the back, and praise the child to the parents; but do not praise the child repeatedly in the child's own presence. Do not lure children with chocolate and similar rewards, and never promise something that cannot be delivered. Do not explain the reasons for a mistake to a child under five: at that age the required understanding has not developed. Discourage mistakes by speech, gesture, voice and facial expression. If necessary, a minor punishment may be given to a child over five, but never strike or humiliate the child or complain about the child. Develop habits of making decisions; help children experience the pleasure of participation; teach healthy competition and self-reliance. Explain matters of temperament, the art of conversation, interpersonal relations, and respect for public property. Teach environmental responsibility, the importance of not hurting others' feelings, and the art of asking questions. Explain what a hero in life should be like, describe the power of inner strength, teach children to understand their village, and help them understand the complexities of religion, politics and caste.

Essential elements for an acting-workshop curriculum:

Analysis of physical and acting abilities; knowledge of anatomy; distinctions among kinds of drama from a sociological perspective; the relation between theatrical production and the means of livelihood, and its effects; relations between theatrical forms and the study of the social, economic, cultural and political environment; development of the arts of learning and understanding; the formulation of a concept, its comprehension and its performance; exercises in movement and speech for acting; and efforts to make theatre part of culture. Introduce historical periods and their drama, and recreate those periods onstage. For this, introduce their history and geography as well as their social, cultural, political and economic conditions. Observing professional theatre gives insight into work carried out behind the stage. Study stage design and costume appropriate to each historical period. Recordings and performances of plays from different periods should be viewed, and photographs, paintings and other information concerning those times collected. Many documentaries can be watched at the Sangeet Natak Akademi in Delhi, where many compact discs are also available for purchase.

4

Modern theatre in Kolkata began around 1850 in British clubs, although outsiders were not admitted. *Vidyāsundar*, a Bengali story of two lovers, was staged on the basis of jātrā. Bhāratendu also wrote on the basis of rāslīlā. Viṣṇudās Bhāve's *Sītā Svayaṃvara* (1843), in Marathi, was an experiment based on the yakṣagāna of Karnataka. Habib Tanvir worked with the poet Nazir in *Agra Bazar* and with Śūdraka's Sanskrit play *Mṛcchakaṭika* in Hindi. Other figures include Shambhu Mitra, B. V. Karanth, K. N. Panikkar and Ratan Thiyam. Thiyam's *Chakravyūha*, based on the story of Abhimanyu, employed song and dance; some people understood it as ballet. Panikkar and Karanth experimented with voice and speech; Karanth also used ālāp. In 1956 the Sangeet Natak Akademi organised its first National Theatre Festival, which opened with Kālidāsa's Sanskrit *Abhijñānaśākuntalam* performed by the Goa Brahmin Sabha. Panikkar staged Bhāsa's *Madhyamavyāyoga* in Sanskrit, while Thiyam staged Bhāsa's *Urubhangam* in Manipuri, with actors entering and leaving slowly in a dance-like style.

Vijay Tendulkar's *Ghashiram Kotwal*, based on Nana Phadnavis and other corrupt Brahmins of Pune and presented in a traditional style drawing upon daśāvatāra, and *Shantata! Court Chalu Aahe*; Girish Karnad's *Hayavadana*, drawing upon the *Kathāsaritsāgara* and yakṣagāna; Mohan Rakesh's *Āṣāṛh kā Ek Din*; Shambhu Mitra's productions of Rabindranath Tagore and Ibsen (*A Doll's House*); and Utpal Dutt's *Kallol* (the sound of waves)—all advanced modern theatre.

5

Parsi theatre: This theatre arose among Mumbai's economically prosperous Parsi community and is called a hybrid, or mixed, theatrical form. It began in 1853 and flourished until about 1940. The advent of cinema brought about its demise, as people connected with it moved into filmmaking. Some celebrated Parsi theatrical works, including *Inder Sabha*, *Alam Ara* and *Khoonne Nahak* (based on Shakespeare's *Hamlet*), were also adapted into films.

Subject matter: Parsi plays drew upon epics and Purāṇas, and their themes were historical and social. Each time the curtain fell, a short comic piece was performed. Parsi theatre was staged both in India and abroad. Excitement and mystery were central to it. Painted curtains were used, and the curtain fell when some mystery was introduced. At an audience's request a scene or song could be repeated: the curtain would rise again for the reprise. Raja Ravi Varma and Parsi theatre influenced each other. Ravi Varma's paintings influenced theatrical costumes and stage decoration,

while he in turn drew inspiration for his subjects from scenes of Parsi theatre.

6

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra:

Drama has two forms, *lokadharmī* and *nāṭyadharmī*. *Lokadharmī* is the ordinary or naturalistic manner, while *nāṭyadharmī* is the classical mode of expression. The ordinary manner rejects artificiality, although some, through ignorance, imagine that the term refers to plays staged in villages. *Lokadharmī* emphasises acting according to natural behaviour, the actions of ordinary people, simple bodily expression, and numerous characters, women as well as men. *Nāṭyadharmī* includes inward speech, speech through gestures, disembodied voices and the like, as well as dance, unusual verbal expression, music in rāgas, and divine characters in addition to ordinary ones. Even inanimate objects or animals may begin to speak; one performer may play two or three roles; and the emotional intensity of happiness and sorrow may be heightened through music.

Lokadharma is the foundation of *nāṭyadharma*. Refine *lokadharmī* and it becomes *nāṭyadharmī*.

Lokadharmī has two types: *cittavṛttyarpikā*, the representation of inward happiness and sorrow, and *bāhyavastvanukāriṇī*, the imitation of external things such as a pond or a lotus-filled lake. *Nāṭyadharmī* likewise has two types: *kaiśikī śobhā*, which displays the body through elegance, song, dance and music, and *aṃśopajīvanī*, the symbolic representation of things such as the Puṣpaka aircraft, mountains or forests.

Acting in its entirety comprises *āṅgika* (through the body), *vācika* (through speech), *sāttvika* (through inward emotion) and *āhārya* (through costumes, staging, decorative objects and imagined visual effects). *Āṅgika abhinaya* operates through the body, face and gesture; *vācika abhinaya* through the languages of gods, kings, non-Aryans, animals and birds. The *sāttvika* expressions comprise *stambha* (immobility arising from joy, fear or grief); *sveda* (sweating, or gestures such as scratching the head in suppressing the emotion of immobility); *romāñca* (bodily horripilation arising from an inward state); *svarabhaṅga* (breaking or heaviness of the voice, tears welling in the eyes); *vepathu* (bodily trembling); *vaivarṇya* (the face turning pale); *aśru* (tears falling in drops, repeatedly or otherwise); and *pralaya* (a swoon, represented, for example, through the corpse pose). *Āhārya* is accomplished through *pusta* (placing figures such as elephants, tigers or mountains onstage), *alaṃkāra* (costume and ornaments), *aṅgaracanā* (colouring, moustaches, dress and hair) and *sañjīva* (presenting living creatures: legless snakes, two-legged human beings and birds, and four-legged animals).

There are two further modes of acting: *sāmānya* and *citrābhinaya* (both discussed in Chapter 22 of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*). After the fourfold classification, *sāmānya abhinaya* is described as a coordinated form of *āṅgika*, *vācika* and *sāttvika* expression, in which the *sāttvika* element predominates. *Citrābhinaya* is related to *āṅgika*: through bodily movements one forms images to enact mountains, ponds, birds and other things.

The staging of drama and acting: Kālidāsa's *Abhijñānaśākuntalam* is essential reading for a theatrical director. Its stage directions include "ratha vegaṃ nirūpya," "sūta paśyainaṃ vyāpādyamānaṃ," "iti śarasaṃdhānam nāṭayati," "vṛkṣa secanam rūpayati," "kalaśam avarjayati," "mukham asyāḥ samunnamayitum icchati," "Śakuntalā pariharati nāṭyena" and "nāṭyena prasādhayataḥ." These actions are performed by acting, not by doing the things themselves. In "nāṭyena prasādhayataḥ," Anasūyā and Priyaṃvadā use gestures to adorn their friend Śakuntalā, whether because the required cosmetics are unavailable or because there is too little time. "Vṛkṣa secanam rūpayati" directs an actor to simulate watering a tree; "kalaśam avarjayati" indicates the imaginary emptying of a pitcher; "ratha vegaṃ nirūpya" represents a swiftly moving chariot; "iti śarasaṃdhānam nāṭayati" indicates the drawing of an arrow to the bow; "sūta paśyainaṃ vyāpādyamānaṃ" directs the representation of a deer being struck down; "mukham asyāḥ samunnamayitum icchati" indicates Duṣyanta's desire to lift Śakuntalā's face; and "Śakuntalā pariharati nāṭyena" directs the enactment of her resistance to his attempt.

Bharata's stage includes a rear curtain; the *nepathya*, understood as a make-up room; doors for entrances and exits; a special curtain concealing the entrances and exits; the *vedikā*, erected in the middle of the stage for the instrumental ensemble; the *raṅgaśīrṣa*, a rear stage area; the *mattavāraṇī*, the two front corners used for acting; and the *raṅgapīṭha*, the main performance space at the front.

Evaluation of acting: In Chapter 27 Bharata identifies success as the aim: the performance must be crowned with success. An audience member who exclaims "Yes!", "Wonderful!", or "What a tragic ending!" is a *sahṛdaya*, in Bharata's terminology, becoming one with the playwright and the characters.

Theatrical competitions were held, and judges distributed prizes there.

Bharata lays down criteria by which judges are to award positive and negative marks:

1. Lack of concentration; 2. Speaking another character's dialogue; 3. Failing to embody the character's personality; 4. Failure of memory; 5.

Departing from one's assigned role and assuming another; 6. Dropping an object or prop; 7. Stumbling over words; 8. Grammatical or other errors; 9. Deficiencies in execution; 10. Defects in music; 11. Defects in speech; 12. Lack of foresight; 13. Deficiencies in materials; 14. Deficiencies in make-up; 15. The insertion by the playwright or director of material from another play; and 16. Failure to make the language of the play simple and clear. These are faults of acting and production.

Judges should be drawn from different fields and be impartial. They should consider the total effect of the play, its continuity, the proportions among its various qualities, and the representation of feeling.

The stage manager, or *sūtradhāra*, and the assistant, or *pāripārśvaka*, should know every aspect of drama. The principal actress should be proficient in music and theatre. The principal actor, or hero, makes a play successful through his ability. Cast the *naṭa*, or performer, according to the role: someone of short stature may suit a boastful warrior; a thin person, a servant; and someone adept at argument or quarrelling, a *bipaṭā*. Choose actors for characters in this way. The head of the musical ensemble, the *taurika*, should know all aspects of music and be able to direct the instrumentalists, or *kuśīlavas*.

7

Maithili drama: Many lectures have discussed the continuity of Maithili and other dramatic traditions from ancient to modern times. The truth, however, is that the stage and dramatic representation described in Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* are no longer available in that form in any part of India or Nepal. Restoring them is certainly a formidable task, but it is not true that no efforts have been made. An uninformed abridgment of Kālidāsa's plays creates grave controversy. Maithili theatre has the possibility of presenting the subsidiary dramatic forms, the *uparūpakas*, by interpreting folk theatre in accordance with the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. The Videha Theatre (and Film) Festival of 2012 is an attempt in this direction.

34. A Parallel World of Maithili Drama and Film

Abstract

Ramkhelawan Mandar came from Katghara village, Shivajinagar block, Samastipur district. Bindeshwar Mandal worked alongside him. People still remember the rising Maithili chorus: "Mother, dear Mother, get me a gun, for I shall become a soldier, Mother."

Keywords: drama · film · parallel · world · literary criticism · Maithili

1

A Parallel World of Maithili Drama

Ramkhelawan Mandar came from Katghara village, Shivajinagar block, Samastipur district. Bindeshwar Mandal worked alongside him. People still remember the rising Maithili chorus: "Mother, dear Mother, get me a gun, for I shall become a soldier, Mother." This troupe performed verse-dramas such as *Reshma-Chuhar*, *Sheet-Basant*, *Alha-Udal* and *Natua Dayal*.

The Maithili-*Bidesiya* troupe performing *Pia Desantar* came from the Saharsa–Supaul–Purnia region.

The short play *Hasan-Husan* was also performed.

The Ramraksha Chaudhary Natya Kala Parishad, based in Gayaghat village, Karian panchayat, Vaidyanathpur post office, Samastipur district, took its production of *Vidyapati* as far as Gorakhpur. Other plays presented by this troupe included *Laungia Merchai*, *Vidyapati*, *Chinik Laddu* and *Basat*.

Efforts must also be made to document and honour this parallel world of Maithili drama.

2

A Parallel World of Maithili Film

Maithili Parallel Cinema:

Mai Ke Mamta, from Dhadkan Media House Pvt. Ltd., Mirchaiya, Siraha, Nepal: presentation by Nandlal Mahato; cinematography by M. Samir; producer Kamal Yadav; writer-director Jitendra Sahayogi.

Artists in Maithili cinema: Abadhesh Kumar Giri, Priyanka Sharma, Rajkumar Mahato, Nirmala Mahato, Anjani Mandal, Nandan Thakur, Dharmendra Sah, Jitendra Thakur, Rita Sahayogi, Nirmala Mahato, Surja Mahato, Pravin Thakur, Dinesh Yadav, Dinesh Thakur, Prem Kumar

Singh, Prem Kumar Mahato, Anil Kumar Mahato, Gyanendra Kumar Mahato, Sanjay Mahato, Dashrath Mahato, Birendra Mahato, Champa Devi, Madhu Devi Mahato, Pushpa Karna, Gulzar Yadav, Ranju Mahato, Indu Sah, Manoj Kumar Singh, Ram Kumar Sah, Ganesh Mahato, Arun Chaudhary, Anil Kumar Sah, Pawan Yadav, Hemlal Yadav, Satya Narayan Mahato, Ganga Mahato, Bharosi Mahato, Baiju Bawra, Akhleshwar Mahato, Dhruv Kumar Mahato, Anil Kumar Das, Vinod Mahato, Santosh Sah, Vipul Sah, Pradeep Sah, Roshan Kumar Ghimire, Manchan Mahato, Jagdish Yadav, Bindeshwar Yadav, Devindra Yadav, Brahmadev Mahato, Indu Mallik, Uttam Mahato, Siyasharan Mahato, Radha Kumari, Saraswati Kumari, Krishna Kumari Mahato, Akash Kumar Mahato, Shivam Chaudhary and Ashish Kumar Mahato.

Special mentions: Rita Kumari Karna, Mithlesh Yadav, Pramod Sah, Rina Yadav, Rekha Mahato, Gyanendra Kumar Mahato, M. Samir, Anil Kumar Mahato, Suresh Yadav, V. P. Udasi, Suresh Mandal, Ramshubhag Mahato, Dev Kumar Mahato, Ramdev Pandit, Anjani Mandal, Mahesh Kushwaha, Birendra Kabirpanthi, Kumar Kushe, Babu Ram Mahato, Dharmendra Sah, Anil Kumar Mahato, Upendra Narayan Mahato, Pawan Mallik, Nandan Thakur and Diwakar Thakuri.

Lyricist: Jitendra Sahayogi.

Music directors: Gurudev Kamat, Kamal Mandal and Vishwanath Jha.

Singers: Gurudev Kamat, Rama Mandal, Harishankar Chaudhary, Vishwanath Jha, Sarmila Mahato and Madhu Gurung.

The Maithili film *Prit Ke Baji*:

A film by G. P. Gupta.

Director: Surya Sah.

Editor: Jitu Singh.

Cinematography: Kundan Kumar Pappu.

Producer: Jivach Prasad Gupta.

Co-producer: Rajkumar Gupta.

Story, subject matter and songs: Shyam Paswan.

Music: Shailendra V. K.

Singers: Jivach, Rajkumar, Sunita and Prabha.

Dance: Ram Thakur and Ajay Thakur.

Action choreography: Kailash Mandal.

The auspicious inauguration of the Maithili feature film *I Love Janakpur*, being made under the banner of Memory Mithila Films Pvt. Ltd., is to take place today, the twenty-fifth day of the month of Shrawan. All journalists, performers, literary figures and lovers of Maithili art are requested to attend at the appointed time and lend dignity to the occasion.

Story and direction:

Nirajan Mehta (Manjit).

Producers:

Pradip Raj and Kamal Mandal.

Music:

Kamal Mandal.

Lyrics: Vineet Thakur.

Venue: Madhesh Media House.

Time: 1 p.m., Shrawan 25.

Hanuman Sthan, Anamnagar,

Kathmandu.

A charity screening of the Maithili film *Mai Ke Mamta* at the Kantipur Hall, Sitapaila, Kathmandu.

Writer and director of *Mai Ke Mamta*: Jitendra Sahayogi.

35. The Impact of Foreign Capital Investment on Languages, Including Maithili

Abstract

Foreign direct investment in India takes place through partnerships with firms from other countries or by purchasing their assets or shares. Investors undertake SWOT analysis and assess their capacity to enter a market by producing at lower cost and greater speed through various methods. The country in which foreign capital will be invested depends on a number of factors.

Keywords: foreign · capital · investment · language · impact · literary criticism · Maithili

Foreign direct investment in India takes place through partnerships with firms from other countries or by purchasing their assets or shares. Investors undertake SWOT analysis and assess their capacity to enter a market by producing at lower cost and greater speed through various methods. The country in which foreign capital will be invested depends on a number of factors. China will attract more foreign capital than India because India has numerous democratic procedures that raise the cost of production. The point may be understood by comparing Japan and Switzerland, which have attracted less foreign capital than Spain. By the same comparison, Nepal will receive proportionately more investment than India. If we examine the prospects for foreign capital in Maithili and other languages, Maithili will attract proportionately more investment than Nepali or Hindi. And, so far as foreign capital is concerned, the future of Maithili in Nepal seems brighter than that of Maithili in India.

Foreign capital, however, is not merely the theoretical outcome of management or economics described above. Political stability and social crisis both confront us here. India's enormous licence fees, which have contributed to Maithili's poor condition in information technology, do not exist in Nepal; consequently Maithili is in a better position on Nepalese radio and television. Yet political instability sometimes obstructs investment in Nepal. Likewise, the social base of Maithili in Nepal is extensive, whereas its base in India is not comparable. This is a negative factor for investment in Maithili in India.

As stated above, before making any foreign capital investment, the investor will conduct a SWOT analysis.

SWOT analysis in the context of Maithili:

Maithili's SWOT analysis—Strength, Weakness, Opportunity and Threat. (My teacher, Chamu Krishna Shastri, has made a very substantial contribution to my understanding of this subject.)

Management studies include a subject called SWOT analysis. Let us examine Maithili against this criterion.

S—Strength: power, capacity, force.

People have a fire in their hearts for Maithili, even when they oppose one another. There is respect for the rise and fall of its intonation and its linguistic distinctiveness; this respect extends even to linguists who do not speak Maithili. The language also possesses spiritual and cultural importance. It has an internal strength. Numerous organisations, including some casteist and communal organisations, are eager to promote its development. Those who know Maithili live not only in India and Nepal but are now dispersed across other countries and regions.

W—Weakness: deficiency, frailty, foolishness.

The culture of praise, which also involves denigrating others, belongs here: it is a form of self-praise.

Mutual flattery belongs here as well. There is dependence on government and an ignorance of priorities; when the language is dying, poets and critics have devoted their lives to becoming, or creating, "great poets." There is an evident absence of a clear plan of action, and everyone is anxious to do something, anything, for Maithili, and proceeds accordingly. A virtual campaign has arisen in which people themselves do not speak Maithili and keep their children away from it; the media, cartoons and the educational system, together with extensive migration within a single generation, have contributed to this. Because Maithili activists are divided into several poles, there is a lack of supportive lobbying. People worry more about the advantage to themselves and their own circle than about what will benefit Maithili. There are too few students of Maithili. Even an excellent product requires marketing skills. In Maithili there is a shortage of excellent products, and marketing skills are lacking as well.

O—Opportunity: possibility, opening, occasion.

There is little writing on specialised subjects; the language relies largely upon stories and poetry. Maithili lacks comics, illustrated narratives, and books on science, social science, spirituality, physics, chemistry, biology and health. Palm-leaf manuscripts are not being published with the aid of computers. Student energies are scarcely used. Teaching is not being

conducted through evening schools, painting or music. There is a great need for Maithili instruction through distance education and the Internet. Translation into Maithili, books on contemporary subjects, and the publication of unpublished palm-leaf manuscripts are necessary. Primary education through Maithili is needed. For migrant Maithils, courses in reading, writing and editing the language are necessary.

T—Threat: danger, potential calamity.

Despair, a sense of inferiority, exclusion from education, the absence of Maithili as a medium of instruction in traditional schools, the scarcity of learned scholars, neglect of palm-leaf manuscripts and their sale abroad, weakening of the language, cultural contamination and the consequent contamination of language, separation from the mainstream and confinement of the language to only two castes, declining levels of knowledge among teachers, and political opposition to Maithili for selfish ends: these are the dangers confronting us.

All the points described above belong within an action plan informed by management science. What is required is work, not speeches. For conversation in Maithili, education through Maithili, and the creation of a new and comprehensive literature, everyone must act with a single direction, a common standard and a united effort. A shortage of funds arises when we continue waiting for government assistance. Rely instead on public support: the shortage is not of donors, but of people willing to receive and organise donations.

According to UNESCO, India is the world's sixth-largest book publisher, producing books in twenty-five recognised languages, including English. In the publication of books in English, India ranks third after the United States and Great Britain. Yet, among the twenty-four major languages, UNESCO considers only eighteen important for book publication, and Maithili is not among those eighteen. According to the Federation of Indian Publishers, India has approximately 16,000 publishers producing around 70,000 books a year. Of these, 21,000 books appear in English, and still more are printed in Hindi. As literacy improves in India, the number of book readers will also rise. In Nepal, books are published principally in Nepali. In both India and Nepal, the publication of Maithili books lags behind in quality as well as quantity.

Cooperation between foreign investors and government institutions: Let us move beyond the publishing industry to other means of disseminating information, such as television, radio and online language tools. Foreign investors can assist us in producing documentaries, entertainment and linguistic tools. If the government works for the recognised languages without making the market its sole concern, particularly with an eye to

Maithili and the other five languages, the cultural decline observable in market-driven information technology need not affect Maithili in the same way. Arabic suffers no shortage of funds, yet why is it dying, despite its use in government, mosques and education? Besides Lebanon, Jordan and Egypt, Saudi Arabia and other Gulf countries protect it. Money, however, has become a source of trouble. Sheikhs return from studies abroad speaking a mixed Arabic, which has become fashionable. A vast difference has developed between the Arabic of the Qur'an and the educational language of the present day, "Modern Standard Arabic" (MSA). This Modern Standard Arabic has separated from spoken Arabic and serves largely as a common link among Arab countries, so that their people may understand one another. Yet it is precisely this Modern Standard Arabic that appears in audiovisual and print media, though it is no one's mother tongue and is learned through the study of grammar. If governments help foreign investors dub entertaining programmes into Maithili, the programmes of cartoon channels and television serials could be broadcast in Maithili whether or not they attract advertising. Once that wheel begins to turn, Maithili will revive. And the wheel will turn only when Brahmins, Kayasthas and other upper-caste Maithils of Madhubani, Darbhanga, Saharsa and Supaul allow the language to revive, suspend their negative energies, and cooperate with, rather than obstruct, all the social groups now becoming associated with Maithili. Only when this proletarian class, endowed with formidable, even demonic talent, forms a dedicated collective effort to protect Maithili will the language survive.

Major foreign investors: HarperCollins, Penguin, Oxford University Press, Macmillan, Random House, Picador, Hachette, Routledge and Howard Business Publishing have invested in the language sector through their branches or Indian partners. But their investment has largely been confined to English. Apart from Penguin Hindi, foreign investment in Indian languages has been almost negligible since foreign companies entered India's publishing industry. The reason is clear. Publishers in Indian languages depend upon government purchases and, outside government procurement, concentrate on printing textbooks. Foreign investors do not determine their policies on the basis of government purchases and textbook production. For Maithili this might have been a blessing. But even if we anticipate a future rise in literacy, it seems almost impossible, given Maithili's marginal position in the present education system, to expect newly literate people to read Maithili. There is no realistic prospect either of government-library purchases or of textbook publication in Maithili. The number of readers must therefore be increased on the Internet, and readers who were never able to study Maithili in the government education system will initially need to be offered free downloads. Through translation from Maithili into English

and Sanskrit, and through these languages into others, books marginalised by governmental and institutional award systems must be brought forward so that foreign investors can encounter the excellence of Maithili literature. At the same time, a dedicated collective effort must secure the teaching of Maithili not only in government schools but in private schools as well. Instead of trading accusations—Kayasthas blaming Brahmins and Brahmins blaming Kayasthas, or people from Madhubani, Saharsa, Madhepura, Samastipur, Begusarai and Purnia blaming one another for Maithili's plight—we must act in one direction, at one level and with one concerted effort. The public must be brought into the movement. Instead of preoccupying ourselves with making awards, we must devote ourselves to recognising writers of the people, leaders of the people, and sellers who can reach the people.

Leave foreign investment aside. Even when an Indian publisher wished to enter this field, or the government purchasing machinery wished to buy a Maithili book, or a voluntary organisation wished to select Maithili books for translation, the leading figures of Maithili literature who became advisers supplied misleading lists. Numerous Mithilakshar manuscripts were taken abroad, and many people created endless disputes. As a result, everyone fled—outsiders as well as those who had come to serve Maithili. Government purchases were not made on the basis of quality but on recommendations, influence and numerous other factors. How can we approach foreign investors while carrying all these negative features?

The indirect impact of foreign investment on Maithili: A reduction in the number of Maithili speakers and a decline in Maithili vocabulary are considered indirect effects of foreign investment. In fact, however, these developments have resulted more from the uncontrolled growth of large cities in India and Nepal and the expansion of small towns through land transactions without an independent economic base. The amount of migration that Maithili speakers have undergone in one generation has occurred over three or four generations among other communities—Tamil- or Bengali-speaking communities, for example. Migration abroad has brought language loss among speakers of other languages too, but it has not entailed the loss of culture, either among those communities or among Maithili speakers. In Delhi, it has become proverbial that members of other communities begin speaking Punjabi after five years in the city and that women in their households start observing Karva Chauth, while Maithili speakers neither learn Punjabi nor adopt Karva Chauth. But if you do not speak Maithili with your wife and never let your child even visit the ancestral village, the child will certainly stop speaking Maithili. Foreign investment in Hindi and English cartoon channels has endangered not only Maithili but Punjabi as well. Yet this is a phase, and it will end within twenty years. Families that stop speaking Maithili during those twenty

years cannot be brought directly back to it. Because of their cultural closeness, however, they will continue to support and respect Maithili projects, translations, audiovisual productions and communication initiatives. This will indirectly prove a blessing for Maithili. A period of renaissance is taking place now, and it will recur twenty years later. Maithili will emerge alive from the struggle and become stronger.

What foreign investors gain from investment in Maithili: Foreign investors also undertake welfare work. They must be made aware of Maithili's special qualities. The late world-renowned violinist Yehudi Menuhin described Maithili as the most rhythmic and melodious language in the world after hearing Vidyapati's music on the BBC, a statement also quoted by Uday Prakash. Some foreign investors make investments on the basis of UNESCO's language policies. Such welfare-oriented investment is not based on profit, government procurement or advertising. If educational books and entertainment- and health-related films and documentaries are produced in Maithili through internationally certified non-governmental organisations and distributed through gram-panchayat schools in Maithili-speaking areas, the sense of inferiority among Maithili speakers will diminish, and an economic revolution will accompany the linguistic revolution.

36. Jayakant Mishra and the Maithili Dictionary

Abstract

Jayakant Mishra (1922–2009), a pioneer of Maithili, died at seven in the evening on 3 February 2009. Dr Jayakant Mishra, a distinguished scholar of Maithili literature, retired in 1982 as Professor and Head of the Department of English and Modern European Languages at the University of Allahabad. He subsequently served as Dean of Languages and Social Sciences at Chitrakoot Gramodaya University.

Keywords: Jayakant · Mishra · Dictionary · Critical Theory · Maithili

Abstract · Abstract

This chapter presents a fieldwork-based study of folk culture concerning "Jayakant Mishra and the Maithili Dictionary". Jayakant, Mishra, Maithili, dictionaries and words emerge as its principal concerns. Through examples, quotations and arguments in the original materials, it compares fieldwork, oral sources and written texts, allowing readers to grasp both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

Jayakant Mishra (1922–2009), a pioneer of Maithili, died at seven in the evening on 3 February 2009. Dr Jayakant Mishra, a distinguished scholar of Maithili literature, retired in 1982 as Professor and Head of the Department of English and Modern European Languages at the University of Allahabad. He subsequently served as Dean of Languages and Social Sciences at Chitrakoot Gramodaya University. The late Mishra was president of the All-India Maithili Sahitya Samiti, Allahabad; honorary secretary and editor of the Ganganath Research Institute, Allahabad; convener of the management department of the Hindi Sahitya Sammelan, Prayag; and Maithili representative and language editor for the Sahitya Akademi, New Delhi. His books included *A History of Maithili Literature*, *Folk Literature of Mithila*, critical editions of the Kīrtaniyā dramas, *Lectures on Thomas Hardy*, *Lectures on Four Poets*, and *The Complex Style in English Poetry*. Only two volumes of his extensive Maithili dictionary could be published. In them, Maithili words appeared not only in Devanagari but also in Mithilakshar and phonetic Roman transcription. Both volumes will remain an inspiration to lexicographers of Maithili. On the basis of the Videha database, the sixteen-volume Maithili–English dictionary compiled by Gajendra Thakur, Nagendra Kumar Jha and the genealogist Vidyanand Jha—which gives words and meanings in Mithilakshar, international phonetic Roman script and Devanagari—has been dedicated to Jayakant Mishra, Dinbandhu Jha–Govind Jha, Bhavnath Mishra–Matinath Mishra 'Matang', and Yugal Kishore Mishra.

Dictionary-making began late in Maithili. The first serious effort consisted of the 1,125 verbal-root forms included in Dinbandhu Jha's *Mithilā Bhāṣā Vidyotana* (1946), followed by his compiled

Mithilābhāṣākoṣaḥ dictionary (1952). Earlier, the first volume of Bhavnath Mishra's *Mithilā Śabda Prakāśa* had appeared in 1914. It was, however, very brief and might be described as a glossary rather than a dictionary.

Alice Irwin Davis's *Basic Colloquial Maithili: A Maithili–Nepali–English Vocabulary* (1984) is also extremely concise. The Maithili Academy's *Maithili Dictionary* (1993; Yugal Kishore Mishra was the original compiler) was the first project to appear on a truly ambitious scale. Yet, amid the names of the convener, editor, executive editor, editorial subcommittee and so forth, Mishra's name appears only in an intermediate position as 'original compiler'.

Meanwhile, the first volume of Jayakant Mishra's *Comprehensive Maithili Dictionary* appeared in 1973 and its second in 1995. Together these volumes could cover words beginning with the vowels from *a* to *au* and only the first page of words beginning with *ka*. With Jayakant Babu's death, publication of the succeeding volumes is no longer possible.

Bhavnath Mishra's son, Matinath Mishra 'Matang', published *Maithili Śabda Kalpadruma* in 1998. After Yugal Kishore Mishra's dictionary for the Maithili Academy, Patna, this was the second dictionary to appear with an enormous lexical collection. The first volume of Bhavnath Mishra's *Mithilā Śabda Prakāśa* is also reproduced at its beginning.

Dinbandhu Jha's son Govind Jha published the *Maithili–English Dictionary* (*Kalyani Kosh*, 1999). Like Jayakant Babu's dictionary, it was bilingual, supplying English meanings alongside Maithili words. In 2007 Umesh Chandra Jha's concise four-language dictionary (*Maithili, Sanskrit, Hindi and English*) also appeared.

In addition to these works, Sajha Prakashan of Nepal has proposed a comprehensive Maithili dictionary.

Dictionaries Based on English-Language Lexical Databases

Apart from historically important English dictionaries, three contemporary works deserve mention for their scientific principles and their reliance on databases or computerised corpora of written and spoken material—newspapers and magazines, books, oral conversation, language used in radio and television programmes, and manuscripts:

1. *Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary* (from its first edition in 1948 to the seventh edition, listed here as 1995);

2. *Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English* (from its first edition in 1978 to the fifth edition in 2009); and

3. *Collins COBUILD Advanced Learner's English Dictionary* (from its first edition in 1995 to the sixth edition in 2008).

The *Microsoft Encarta Dictionary*, available on CD and online, also provides audio recordings of pronunciation; CD editions of the *Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary* and other dictionaries likewise supply such recordings.

The excellence of a dictionary should be judged by the collection of words it contains. First, the reader must find the word being sought. This cannot happen unless the dictionary is up to date, based on fieldwork—covering every region of Mithila and new usages among migrant Maithils—and inclusive of emerging fields, such as the Internet, science, the arts, commerce, computing and contemporary developments. Scholarship must be joined to technology in choosing the subject matter. Sports and play, informal conversation, written literature and oral literature must all be included. The definition of each word is equally important: the selected word demands an analysis of such linguistic precision that no context or shade of meaning is lost. In this connection, Dinbandhu Jha's 1,125 verbal-root forms deserve attention. If these were further enlarged and revised to approximately 2,000 fundamental words, Maithili speakers lacking a firm command of their language could understand the meanings and contexts of the entries in a Maithili dictionary of 50,000–100,000 words.

The meanings of words should be arranged from their most frequent to their less frequent senses. Oral pronunciation and actual usage must also receive attention. Readers should be told which words are common and which are used only occasionally. Proverbs, too, should be illustrated with examples wherever appropriate.

Alongside an entry, it is essential to record compounds, compound expressions formed from proverbs, derivatives of a word, synonyms and antonyms. The association of a word or idiom with other words, and its use in the same or a closely related sense, must likewise be demonstrated.

Grammatical discussion should be provided at suitable places, indicating both similarities and differences. Changes in a word's meaning according to its use in a sentence must be shown.

Illustrations are also necessary to explain entries in a dictionary. A modern scientific dictionary must record variations in pronunciation.

The contextual uses of idioms and proverbs must be given. For example, a Brahmin may say, 'Ten Brahmins, ten stomachs; ten *rāṛ*, one stomach,' whereas someone on what is called the lower rung of the caste hierarchy may say, 'Ten Brahmins, one stomach; ten *rāṛ*, ten stomachs.' Such competing usages should be recorded wherever they exist.

Words must be shown in sentences. Giving only a few words as their meaning leads to numerous incorrect usages. This can be corrected by

showing the entry within a complete sentence. Examples can even be taken from poetry, where complete sentences are also employed.

Software dictionaries should be developed so that a dictionary can be presented on CD or the Internet, with phonetic and spoken examples.

Phonetic transcription: the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA) is the most widely used system of phonetic transcription, and its use is necessary in bilingual and multilingual dictionaries.

Jayakant Mishra and the Maithili Dictionary

In the personal statement prefacing the first volume of his Maithili dictionary, Jayakant Mishra writes that Dr Subhadra Jha—whom he regards as Maithili's foremost linguist and who was formerly librarian of Varanaseya Sanskrit University—showed as much reluctance to assume the responsibility of chief editor of the dictionary as he had displayed in 1965 when Maithili was being recognised as India's seventeenth literary language at the Sahitya Akademi. Mishra drew on Subhadra Jha's *The Formation of the Maithili Language* (1958) for notes on the etymology of Maithili words, as Suniti Kumar Chatterji observes in his introduction to the first volume. Jayakant Mishra's dictionary established a benchmark for many other reasons as well, including the following.

1. **Assembly of contemporary lexical material.** Sources included Dinbandhu Jha's *Mithilābhāṣā Śabdakośa*; Badrinath Jha's *Maithili–Sanskrit Dictionary*; Sir George A. Grierson's *Bihar Peasant Life* and Maithili dictionary in the *Maithili Chrestomathy* (1882); Dr Subhadra Jha's material from Sarvananda's commentary on the *Amarakośa*; Mahamahopadhyaya Dr Umesh Mishra; the vocabularies of Ruchipati, Jagaddhara and Vidyapati; words extracted from the *Caryāgīti* edited by N. N. Vasu; from the *Varṇaratnākara* edited by Suniti Kumar Chatterji and Babuaji Mishra; from Vidyapati's poems edited by Khagendranath Mitra and Majumdar; from *Kṛṣṇajanma* edited by Sir George Grierson; and proverb collections edited by Surendra Jha 'Suman', Riddhinath Jha and Rameshwar Jha.

2. **Published books and published manuscripts as references.** These included Jyotirishwar's Maithili *Dhūrtasamāgama* (1324), Vidyapati's *Gorakṣavijaya* (1415), Kanharam's *Gaurī Svayaṃvara* (1842), and works by Lochan, Govinddas, Chanda Jha, Harshanath Jha, Laldas, Harimohan Jha, Suman, Yatri and others.

3. **Periodicals with long publication histories.** *Mithila Mihir*, *Mithila Mod* and *Vaidehi* were used as sources.

4. **An audio corpus.** Spoken and dialect forms of words were collected with tape recorders, and agricultural and boatmen's vocabularies were gathered.

Vocabulary relating to paddy, mangoes, original villages and genealogical registers was nevertheless omitted.

5. **First attestations.** The earliest recorded use of a word was determined from the corpus and documented in the dictionary. Shri Shashinath Chaudhary of Mishra Tola contributed to this work.

6. **Type and transcription.** The dictionary used Tirhuta type prepared by the Rajaram Type Foundry Press, Katghar, Allahabad, under the guidance of Mahamahopadhyaya Dr Umesh Mishra. Roman phonetic transcription was also used to clarify pronunciation.

7. **Scholarly assistance.** Dr Sir Ganganath Jha, Dr Amarnath Jha and Mahamahopadhyaya Dr Umesh Mishra helped gather books and periodicals for the dictionary. Professor Harimohan Jha, Babu Lakshmipati Singh, Professor Buddhidhari Singh Ramakar, Professor Surendra Jha 'Suman' and Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran' served as unpaid advisers. The assistant editors were Raghavacharya Shastri, Dr Umakant Tiwari, Jaygovind Mishra, Professor Sushil Chandra Chaudhary, Jiveshwar Jha, Yashodhar Jha, Dr Kishorenath Jha and Professor Rudrakant Mishra.

8. **Grammatical analysis.** Meanings were divided into numbered senses such as 1 and 2, according to usage. The entries provided grammatical information, including obsolete words and poetic uses; etymology for indigenous and borrowed words; comparisons, antonyms and synonyms where appropriate; and corpus-derived example sentences containing the word being defined.

Dinbandhu Jha's *Dhātupāṭha* in *Mithilā Bhāṣā Vidyotana* gives excellent semantic derivations. For example, '(10) ḍik—to hold or contain more': 'This place is deep, so water has *ḍikal* here'—that is, more water has been contained there. The forty-three tables in the two volumes of *Mithilā Bhāṣā Vidyotana* set out Maithili etymologies in detail. The introduction to Dinbandhu Jha's *Mithilā Bhāṣā Koṣa* likewise discusses the formation, pronunciation, grammatical gender and grammar of many words. In the dictionary proper, though not for every entry, most words are accompanied by their component analysis, grammatical features and meanings. Variants of words and differences in meaning caused by their association with verbs or other words are also indicated here and there.

Yugal Kishore Mishra's dictionary for the Maithili Academy, Patna, provides a word, then its grammatical characteristics and meaning. Alice Irwin Davis's *Basic Colloquial Maithili: A Maithili–Nepali–English Vocabulary* (1984) uses only Roman and phonetic Roman letters. It gives Maithili words, grammatical characteristics, and their meanings in Nepali and English. After several structural notes, Nepali and English indexes

allow meanings to be retrieved from Nepali into Maithili and from English into Maithili.

In Bhavnath Mishra's *Mithilā Śabda Prakāśa*, the word appears in Maithili, followed by its Hindi and Sanskrit meanings, grammatical gender, and finally Sanskrit evidence. Matinath Mishra 'Matang's' *Maithili Śabda Kalpadruma* gives the Maithili word, its grammatical features and meaning, and then identifies whether it is Maithili, indigenous, *tatsama* or *tadbhava*.

Along with an introductory analysis of structure and pronunciation, the appendices to Govind Jha's *Kalyani Kosh: A Maithili–English Dictionary* contain tables of verbal suffixes, nominal suffixes and units; solar months and lunar mansions; lunar months; different calendrical eras; weights and measures, linear measures and square measures; currency; and miscellaneous counting systems. The dictionary itself gives the Maithili headword in Devanagari, its Roman phonetic transcription, its grammatical characteristics and its meanings in Maithili and English. Alternative senses and contexts are given in some places. Umesh Chandra Jha's four-language dictionary lists a Maithili word with its Sanskrit, Hindi and English equivalents. In C-DAC's software-based Maithili–English and English–Maithili dictionary, entering a Maithili word produces its English meaning, while entering an English word produces its Maithili equivalent.

The Maithili–English and English–Maithili dictionaries prepared by Gajendra Thakur, Nagendra Kumar Jha and the genealogist Vidyanand Jha draw on the Videha corpus. They are available in print and online (http://www.videha.co.in/) and are continuously expanded. They include Internet, computing and scientific terminology along with other modern subjects. In the present Maithili–English dictionary, the Maithili headword is given in the International Phonetic Alphabet, followed by transliteration into Devanagari and Mithilakshar, and then its meaning in the IPA, Devanagari and Mithilakshar, with an English meaning and grammatical particulars at the end. The English–Maithili dictionary based on the Videha corpus gives an English word and its grammatical particulars, then its meaning in the IPA, Devanagari and Mithilakshar, and finally its meaning in English.

After the complete database has appeared in print, a second edition is planned in which definitions will be arranged from their most frequent to least frequent meanings. It will also include compound words, compound expressions based on proverbs, derivatives, synonyms and antonyms, grammatical discussion showing both similarity and difference in the

words associated with idioms, illustrative pictures, contextual uses of idioms and proverbs, and example sentences drawn from the Videha corpus. A software dictionary on CD, containing phonetic recordings, is also planned. Audio pronunciation files are already available to download or hear online in the archive at http://www.videha.co.in/.

Jayakant Mishra and the Maithili Dictionary: An Assessment

A dictionary is not written so much as collected. When a subject is new, however, new words have to be coined with reference to the oral and literary traditions, and loanwords must sometimes be accepted. The dictionary's immediate objective may be collection, but, whether its editor wishes it or not, it advances the process of standardisation and influences everyday usage. The editor's responsibility therefore increases.

In this respect, Jayakant Mishra's dictionary is in no way inferior to a modern dictionary. Indeed, it goes one step further by providing corpus-based sentences to determine meanings, supported by references from ancient Maithili (from the eighth century to 1324, including the *Caryāpada* and Jyotirishwar); the earlier medieval period (1324–1500, including Vidyapati); the medieval period (1500–1860, including Lochan and Govinddas); and modern Maithili (1860–1960, including Chanda Jha and Harimohan Jha).

Jayakant Mishra's *Maithili Dictionary* and the scholarship surrounding Jayakant Mishra and Maithili lexicography can thus complement one another—provided the work he began is carried forward and completed.

37. Administrative and Social Vocabulary Found in the Pañjī System

Abstract

The account below presents certain administrative and social terms collected through the examination of 11,000 JPG images of palm-leaf genealogical registers (pañjī), as described below …

Keywords: Pañjī · Genealogical Administration · Administrative Vocabulary · Social Vocabulary · Critical Studies

Abstract · Abstract

This chapter presents a narrative-literary critical study of "Administrative and Social Vocabulary Found in the Pañjī System". The genealogical administration, its available administrative and social vocabulary, and the terminology itself are central concerns. On the basis of examples, quotations and arguments in the source material, it examines narrative content, characters, structure, language and social meaning so that readers may understand both the critical organisation of the subject and its broader setting.

The following administrative and social vocabulary was collected by examining 11,000 JPG images of palm-leaf genealogical registers (*pañjī*).

Administrative, scholarly and social designations recorded in the genealogical registers include *sāndhivigrahika* (an officer concerned with treaties and disputes), *dharmādhyakṣa* (religious or judicial overseer), *caturvedādhyāyī* (scholar of the four Vedas), *yājñika* (ritual officiant), *pārṇāgārika*, *vārtika*, *mahāmāttaka*, *bhāṇḍāgārika* (treasury officer), *sthānāntarika*, *rājavallabha*, *raula*, *khaṇatarī*, *kāpani*, *phūlahara*, *purohita*, *kulakṣetropāryaka*, *āvasthika*, *kaṇṭakoddhārakāraka*, *jyotirvid* (astronomer or astrologer), *padāṅkita*, *paṇḍitarāja*, *upāyakāraka* and *ekāntarika*. Further entries designate persons as *vaidika* (Vedic scholar), *vaiyākaraṇa* (grammarian), *āgamācārya* (teacher of the Āgamas), *tarka-pañcānana*, *kavi*, *kavirāja*, *kaviśekhara*, *kavikeśarī*, *kavīndra*, *kavimaṇi*, *mīmāṃsaka* (scholar of Mīmāṃsā), *naiyāyika* (logician), *devāgārika*, *dharma-adhikaraṇika* (judicial or religious court functionary), *naivandhika*, and *mudrāhastaka* (seal-holder). Among those identified in association with these titles are Vishvambhar, Purandar, Gonu Jha, Ghanashyam, Ganapati Mishra, Pitambar, Kulapati, Chaturbhuj, Madhav, Vireshwar, Bhagirath, Dhananath, Jivapati, Krishnadev, Baldev, Kaladhar, Nityanand, Badrinath, Chandradatt, Amritnath, Buddhinnath, Devnath, Radhnath, Dinbandhu, Matinath, Harshanath, Brajgopal, Jaygopal, Chintamani, Padmanabh, Gangadas, Ratidev, Yadunath, Bhupat, Yashodhar, Vidyapati, Bhanudatt, Janardana, Durgadhar, Udayakant, Jayadatt, Narasimha, Gadadhar, Gunishwar and Lakshmipati. The entries often give a village or ancestral origin, the father–son relationship, scholarly title, and an abbreviated reference number. The full source transcription, preserving its duplicates, variant spellings, abbreviations, names and numerical references, follows:

Archival Register — Original Transcription

सांधिविग्रहिक, धर्माध्यक्षक, चतुर्वेदाध्यायी, याज्ञिक, पार्णागारिक, वार्तिक, महामत्तक, भाण्डागारिक, स्थानान्तरिक, राजवल्लभराजवल्लभ, स्थानान्तरिक, राउल, खनतरी, कापनि, फूलहर, सन्धि बिग्रहिक, पुरोहित, कुल छेत्रोपार्यक, आवस्थिक, कन्टकोद्धार्कारक, ज्योतिविर्वद, पदांकित, पण्डित राज पदांकित, उपाय कारक, एकान्तरिक, माण्डर सँ वैदिक विश्वम्भर, सिहौली माण्डरसँ पुरन्दर सुत वैदिक गोनू झा, नर वलि. सँ घनश्याम सुत वैदिक गणपति मिश्र, खौआलसँ कमल सुत म. गुणाकर वैदिक पिताम्बर, सिंहौलि माण्डरसँ वैदिक विश्वम्भर सुत म. कुलपति म. चतुर्भुज, दरिहरासँ रघुनाथ सुत म. माधव वैदिक विरेश्वर, दरिहरासँ म. माधव सुत वैदिक भगीरथ, दरिहरासँ कीर्तिनाथ

सुत वैदिक धननाथ, दरिहरासँ रामसुत वैदिक भगीरथ, सकराढ़ीसँ नकटू सुत वैदिक चन्दरक्त, माण्डर सँ वै. अच्छपति सुत वैदिक जीवपति, सोदरपुरसँ वैदिक होरी, दरिहरा सँ राम द्दौ० विभाकर सुतौ वैदिक विश्वम्भर, सकराढ़ीसकराढ़ी सँ हरिश्वर द्दौ० वैदिक: विश्वम्भर, माण्डर सँ वैदिक विश्वम्भर, कमल सुतो कृष्णदेव महो गुणाकरौ (१०९//०४) वैदिक (१०९/०४) पीताम्बरा:, माण्डरसँ माण्डरसँ भैरव द्दौ० वैदिक विधूप्र०, वैदिक युदनाथ:, वैदिकवैदिक विरेश्वर, वैदिकवैदिक भगीरथ, वैदिक विश्नाथ, वैदिक घननाथ, वैदिक चन्द्रदत्त, दरिहरा सँ वैदिक जीवनाथ, वैदिक अच्छपति, वैदिकवैदिक बलदेव, दरिहरा सँ वैदिक जीवनाथ दौहित्र दौ, वैदिकवैदिक कलाघर, दरिहरा सँ राम सुत वैदिक भगीरथ दौ, वैदिक राजा महो गोशाई, वैदिक मुकुन्द, बेचू सुतो वैयाकरण धरनीघर वैदिक वनखण्डीकौ, वैदिक नित्यानन्द, वैदिक सोनी, वैदिक बद्रीनाथ, वैदिकवैदिक विधु, हरिअम सँ मुक्तिनाथ द्दौ०वैदिक तुलानन्द, वैदिक चन्द्रदत्त प्रेमदत्त, सोदरपुरसोदरपुर सँ चित्रधर द्दौ० वैदिक धननाथ, वैदिकवैदिक अमोदयानाथ, वैदिक हेमागंद, वैदिक गणपति वैदिक कुलपतिको, बैदिक गुणपति सुता आँखी वैदिक कलाघर, अपरा वैदिक कुलमणि, वैदिकवैदिक आदिनाथ, वैदिक कुलपति, ज्यो., वैयाकरणवैयाकरण भैरवदत्तौ, वैयाकरण अमृतनाथ बुद्धिनाथ देवनाथ, वैयाकरण राम:, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण राधनाथ, वैयाकरण परमेश्वर, सरिसबसरिसब सँ झोटह द्दौ०वैयाकरण नन्दीपति, वैयाकरण गौरीशंकर, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण रज्जे, खण्डबला सँ भगीरथ द्दौ. महा वैयाकरण दिनबन्धु सुता वैया. जीवनाथ, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण मतिनाथ, सकुरीपाली सँ वैयाकरण श्रीदत्त सुत वै. मनभरन दौ, वैयाकरण रूपनाथ, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण मतिनाथा:, कविकवि हेमनाथ सुता वैयाकरण महिनाथ, वैयाकरण रामनाथ उँमानाथ:, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण खुशिहाल, वैयाकरण भवानीदत्त देवीदत्ता, वैयाकरण हेमनाथ दौ, वैयाकरण हरिनाथा:, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण ऋद्धि, छक्कनछक्कन वैयाकरण, महो चण्डेश्वर सुतो वैयाकरण (२७६//०७) शिवेश्वर:, खौआल सँ वैयाकरण मोदनाथ दौ, वैयाकरण (२०१/०४) मोदनाथ, वैयाकरण गोपाला:, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण मेघनादौ, वैयाकरण चंलल:, वैयाकरण ईश्वरीदत्त सुतो, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण हर्षनाथ दौ, वैयाकरण (०४/०६) ब्रजगोपाल जयगोपाल वैयाकरण प्राध्यापक (Calcutta university Maithily Deptt.) खूद्दीका महिषी पाली सँ दिनानाथ सुत शक्तिनाथ दौ, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण महावीर, वैयाकरण हरिनारायणा, वैयाकरण नन्दीपति, वैयाकरण एकनाथ, कुजौली सँ गंगादत दौ वैयाकरण रघुनाथ, हरिअम सँ

तुलसीदत्त द्वौ वैयाकरण खुद्दी, अपरावैयाकरण सुता वैयाकरण भैये सुग्गे, वैयाकरण चिन्तामनि, देयाम सँ वैयाकरण मधुकर, पिताम्बर सुतो वैयाकरण पद्मनाम, वैयाकरणवैयाकरण रवूदीका, हरिअम सँ हिंगु द्वौ वैदिक सोनी सुता वैदिक कुलमणि वैदिक वंशमणि कमलमणि परशमणि (२८०/०१) हर्षमणिका: दरिहरा सँ वैदिक जीवनाथ दौ, पाली सँ श्रीनाथ द्वौ पुरन्दर सुतो वैदिक गोनू वैदिक हेमाङ्गदो, वैदिक घनश्याम, खौआलसँ काशीपति द्वौ वैदिक घनश्ययाम (१६०/०५) सुतो वैदिक गणपति वैदिक ब., वैदिक गणपति सुता ऑखी वैदिक कलाधर (२६८/०९) रकनी कविभानु वैदिक, वैदिक केशव, वैदिक गोशाइका:, वैदिकवैदिक गोशाँई, सरिसब सँ चतुर्भूज द्वौ० वैदिक गिरधारी, आदिनाथा: ब., माण्डरसँ वैदिक विश्वम्भर, आगमाचार्यक म० म० उपा० (९६//०४) देवनाथ, आगमाचार्यक देवनाथ, एकहरा सँ आगमाचार्यक महो मुकुन्द, कन्टकोद्धार्कारक म०म० मधुसूदन, तर्क पञ्चानन म० म० उपा० गोपीनाथ, विरेश्वर कविशेखर इति प्रसिद्ध, कटाइ सँ कवि केशरी म०म० भीम, माण्डर सँ कविराज शुभंकर, वलियास सँ कविशेखर पदांकित चन्द्रनाथ, सोदरपुरसोदरपुर सँ ढाका कवि महामहो गणपति, कुजौली सँ महो कृष्ण दाशसुत कवि गंगादाश, करमहा सँ कविन्द्र पदांकित रति देव, दरिहरा सँ कविराज विसव, करमहा सँ कविन्द्र पदांकित रतिदेव, टकवाल सँ कविराज लक्ष्मीपाणि, पाली सँ कविशेखर पदांकित यदुनाथ, विस्फी सँ कवि भूपति पदांकित सोमेश्वर, माण्डर सँ कविशेखर पदांकित महो यशोधर, जगति सँ महामहोकवि रत्न पदां. होरे, पाली सँ घौघे सुत कविराज कृष्णपति, वलियास सँ कविशेखर पदांकित चन्द्रनाथ, वलियास सँ कवि मणि पदांकित पशुपति, गंगोली सँ कविराज गयन, ए सुतो महामहो विद्यापति गंगोली सँ मानकुढ वासी कविराज गणेश्वर, सोदरपुरसँ कविराज महो भानुदत्त, सोदरपुरसोदरपुर सँ कवि जयराम, तपोवन सँ कवि धनेश्वर, अलय सँ शान्तिकरणीक रूद, नरवाल सँ शान्तिकरणीक मधुकर, कलिगाम सँ शान्तिकरणीक भोगीश्वर, माण्डरसँ शान्तिकरणीक पाँखू, दानाधिकारी मोदी हल्लेश्वर, जगतिसँ मिमांशक म. म. मिरुस, (मिमांशक) हरि देवधरापत्य-सिंघिया, मिश्रा (मिमांशक) सुधाधरपत्य उसरौली, मिश्र (मिमांशक) लाखू भूड़ी गणेश्वर-परमगढ, मिमांशक विभू, मिमांशक माधव, भवेश्वर सुता मिमांशक रूद, नोने सुता मिमांशक मिसरू, राम सुतो मिमांशक योगदत्त:, मिमांशक मेघानाथ, मिमांशक मणि, मिमांशक जयदेव, मिमांशक धरनी, मिमांशक योगदत्त:, करमहा सँ मिमांशक योगदत्त, जगतिसँ मिमांशक म. म. मिरुस, जनार्दन सुत

नैयायिक दुर्गाधर, नैयायिक महौ दुर्गाधर, षट्शास्त्री नैयायिक दर्शनशास्त्रज्ञ उदयकान्तो, दिघो सँ देवागारिक बाटे, दिघो सँ देवागारिक बटेश्वर, पार्णागारिक विरेश्वर, दिघोयसँ पार्णागारिक जानू दत्त, पार्णा गारिक स्थितिदत्त, धर्माधिकरणिक जानुदत्त, पबौली सँ धर्माधिकरणिक रूद, गंगोली सँ धर्माधिकरणिक जान्हव, धर्माधिकरणिक महामहो नरहरि, धर्माधिकरणिक गदाधर, सुरगन सँ धर्माधिकरणिक भास्कर, करिअमसँ म.म. धर्माधिकरणिक मरथ, खौआलसँ शर्म्मा धर्माधिकरणिक म.म. उ.हरिशर्म्मा, दिघोयसँ जयदत्त सुत धर्माधिकरणिक भट्टजीवे, धर्माधिकरणिक म.म. (२३/०१०) नरसिंह, धर्माधिकरणिक महोमहोपाध्याय गदाधर, धर्माधिकरणिक वाटू, नैवंधिक-नैवंधिक वीरेश्वर, नैवंधिकधीरेश्वर, मुद्राहस्तक गुणीश्व, सुत म.म. आभो एसुत, मुद्राहस्तक कुल छेत्रोपार्यक राउल, गढ़बेलउँच सँ मुद्राहस्तक गुणीश्वर, मुद्राहस्तक लक्षपति, मुद्राहस्तक लक्ष्मीदत्त

Archival Register — Roman Transliteration

sāṃdhivigrahika, dharmādhyakṣaka, caturvedādhyāyī, yājñika, pārṇāgārika, vārtika, mahāmattaka, bhāṇḍāgārika, sthānāntarika, rājavallabharājavallabha, sthānāntarika, rāula, khanatarī, kāpani, phūlahara, sandhi bigrahika, purohita, kula chetropāryaka, āvasthika, kaṇṭakoddhārkāraka, jyotivirvada, padāṃkita, paṇḍita rāja padāṃkita, upāya kāraka, ekāntarika, māṇḍara saṁ vaidika viśvambhara, sihaulī māṇḍarasaṁ purandara suta vaidika gonū jhā, nara vali. saṁ ghanaśyāma suta vaidika gaṇapati miśra, khauālasaṁ kamala suta ma. guṇākara vaidika pitāmbara, siṃhauli māṇḍarasaṁ vaidika viśvambhara suta ma. kulapati ma. caturbhuja, dariharāsaṁ raghunātha suta ma. mādhava vaidika vireśvara, dariharāsaṁ ma. mādhava suta vaidika bhagīratha, dariharāsaṁ kīrtinātha suta vaidika dhananātha, dariharāsaṁ rāmasuta vaidika bhagīratha, sakarāḍhīsaṁ nakaṭū suta vaidika candarakta, māṇḍara saṁ vai. acchapati suta vaidika jīvapati, sodarapurasaṁ vaidika horī, dariharā saṁ rāma ddauo vibhākara sutau vaidika viśvambhara, sakarāḍhīsakarāḍhī saṁ hariśvara ddauo vaidika: viśvambhara, māṇḍara saṁ vaidika viśvambhara, kamala suto kṛṣṇadeva maho guṇākarau (109//04) vaidika (109/04) pītāmbarā:, māṇḍarasaṁ māṇḍarasaṁ bhairava ddauo vaidika vidhūprao, vaidika yudanātha:, vaidikavaidika vireśvara, vaidikavaidika bhagīratha, vaidika viśnātha, vaidika ghananātha, vaidika candradatta, dariharā saṁ vaidika jīvanātha, vaidika acchapati, vaidikavaidika baladeva, dariharā saṁ vaidika jīvanātha dauhitra dau, vaidikavaidika kalāghara, dariharā saṁ rāma suta vaidika bhagīratha dau, vaidika rājā maho gośāī, vaidika mukunda, becū suto vaiyākaraṇa dharanīghara vaidika vanakhaṇḍīkau, vaidika nityānanda, vaidika sonī, vaidika badrīnātha, vaidikavaidika vidhu, hariama saṁ muktinātha ddauovaidika tulānanda, vaidika candradatta premadatta, sodarapurasodarapura saṁ citradhara ddauo vaidika dhananātha, vaidikavaidika amodayānātha, vaidika hemāgaṃda, vaidika gaṇapati vaidika kulapatiko, baidika guṇapati sutā āṁkhī vaidika kalāghara, aparā vaidika kulamaṇi, vaidikavaidika ādinātha, vaidika kulapati, jyo., vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa bhairavadattau, vaiyākaraṇa amṛtanātha buddhinātha devanātha, vaiyākaraṇa rāma:, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa rādhanātha, vaiyākaraṇa parameśvara, sarisabasarisaba saṁ jhoṭaha ddauovaiyākaraṇa nandīpati, vaiyākaraṇa gaurīśaṃkara, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa rajje, khaṇḍabalā saṁ bhagīratha ddau. mahā vaiyākaraṇa dinabandhu sutā vaiyā. jīvanātha, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa matinātha, sakurīpālī saṁ vaiyākaraṇa śrīdatta suta vai. manabharana dau, vaiyākaraṇa rūpanātha, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa matināthā:, kavikavi hemanātha sutā vaiyākaraṇa mahinātha, vaiyākaraṇa rāmanātha umāmānātha:,

vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa khuśihāla, vaiyākaraṇa bhavānīdatta devīdattā, vaiyākaraṇa hemanātha dau, vaiyākaraṇa harināthā:, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa ṛddhi, chakkanachakkana vaiyākaraṇa, maho caṇḍeśvara suto vaiyākaraṇa (276//07) śiveśvara:, khauāla saṁ vaiyākaraṇa modanātha dau, vaiyākaraṇa (201/04) modanātha, vaiyākaraṇa gopālā:, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa meghanādau, vaiyākaraṇa caṃlala:, vaiyākaraṇa īśvarīdatta suto, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa harṣanātha dau, vaiyākaraṇa (04/06) brajagopāla jayagopāla vaiyākaraṇa prādhyāpaka (Calcutta university Maithily Deptt.) khūddīkā mahiṣī pālī saṁ dināntha suta śaktinātha dau, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa mahāvīra, vaiyākaraṇa harinārāyaṇā, vaiyākaraṇa nandīpati, vaiyākaraṇa ekanātha, kujaulī saṁ gaṃgādata dau vaiyākaraṇa raghunātha, hariama saṁ tulasīdatta ddau vaiyākaraṇa khuddī, aparāvaiyākaraṇa sutā vaiyākaraṇa bhaiye sugge, vaiyākaraṇa cintāmani, deyāma saṁ vaiyākaraṇa madhukara, pitāmbara suto vaiyākaraṇa padmanāma, vaiyākaraṇavaiyākaraṇa ravūdīkā, hariama saṁ hiṃgu ddau vaidika sonī sutā vaidika kulamaṇi vaidika vaṃśamaṇi kamalamaṇi paraśamaṇi (280/01) harṣamaṇikā: dariharā saṁ vaidika jīvanātha dau, pālī saṁ śrīnātha ddau purandara suto vaidika gonū vaidika hemāḍgado, vaidika ghanaśyāma, khauālasaṁ kāśīpati ddau vaidika ghanaśyayāma (160/05) suto vaidika gaṇapati vaidika ba., vaidika gaṇapati sutā ŏṃkhī vaidika kalādhara (268/09) rakanī kavibhānu vaidika, vaidika keśava, vaidika gośāikā:, vaidikavaidika gośāmī, sarisaba saṁ caturbhūja ddauo vaidika giradhārī, ādināthā: ba., māṇḍarasaṁ vaidika viśvammara, āgamācāryaka mao mao upāo (96//04) devanātha, āgamācāryaka devanātha, ekaharā saṁ āgamācāryaka maho mukunda, kaṇṭakoddhārkāraka maōmaō madhusūdana, tarka patrcānana mao mao upāo gopīnātha, vireśvara kaviśekhara iti prasidva, kaṭāi saṁ kavi keśarī maōmaō bhīma, māṇḍara saṁ kavirāja śubhaṃkara, valiyāsa saṁ kaviśekhara padāṃkita candranātha, sodarapurasodarapura saṁ ḍhākā kavi mahāmaho gaṇapati, kujaulī saṁ maho kṛṣṇa dāśasuta kavi gaṃgādāśa, karamahā saṁ kavindra padāṃkita rati deva, dariharā saṁ kavirāja visava, karamahā saṁ kavindra padāṃkita ratideva, ṭakavāla saṁ kavirāja lakṣmīpāṇi, pālī saṁ kaviśekhara padāṃkita yadunātha, visphī saṁ kavi bhūpati padāṃkita someśvara, māṇḍara saṁ kaviśekhara padāṃkita maho yaśodhara, jagati saṁ mahāmahokavi ratna padāṃ. hore, pālī saṁ ghaughe suta kavirāja kṛṣṇapati, valiyāsa saṁ kaviśekhara padāṃkita candranātha, valiyāsa saṁ kavi maṇi padāṃkita paśupati, gaṃgolī saṁ kavirāja gayana, e suto mahāmaho vidyāpati gaṃgolī saṁ mānakuḍha vāsī kavirāja gaṇeśvara, sodarapurasaṁ kavirāja maho bhānudatta, sodarapurasodarapura saṁ kavi jayarāma, tapovana saṁ kavi dhaneśvara, alaya saṁ śāntikaraṇīka rūda, naravāla saṁ śāntikaraṇīka madhukara, kaligāma saṁ śāntikaraṇīka bhogīśvara, māṇḍarasaṁ śāntikaraṇīka pāṁkhū, dānādhikārī modī halleśvara, jagatisaṁ mimāṃśaka ma. ma. mirusa, (mimāṃśaka) hari devadharāpatya-siṃghiyā, miśrā (mimāṃśaka) sudhādharapatya usaraulī, miśra (mimāṃśaka) lākhū bhūḍī gaṇeśvara-paramagaḍha, mimāṃśaka vibhū, mimāṃśaka mādhava, bhaveśvara sutā mimāṃśaka rūda, none sutā mimāṃśaka misarū, rāma suto mimāṃśaka yogadatta:, mimāṃśaka meghānātha, mimāṃśaka maṇi, mimāṃśaka jayadeva, mimāṃśaka dharanī, mimāṃśaka yogadatta:, karamahā saṁ mimāṃśaka yogadatta, jagatisaṁ mimāṃśaka ma. ma. mirusa, janārdana suta naiyāyika durgāghara, naiyāyika mahau durgādhara, ṣaṭśāstrī naiyāyika darśanaśāstrajña udayakānto, digho saṁ devāgārika bāṭe, digho saṁ devāgārika baṭeśvara, pārṇāgārika vireśvara, dighoyasaṁ pārṇāgārika jānū datta, pārṇā gārika sthitidatta, dharmādhikaraṇika jānudatta, pabaulī saṁ dharmādhikaraṇika rūda, gaṃgolī saṁ dharmādhikaraṇika jānhava, dharmādhikaraṇika mahāmaho narahari, dharmādhikaraṇika gadādhara, suragana saṁ dharmādhikaraṇika bhāskara, kariamasaṁ ma. ma. dharmādhikaraṇika maratha, khauālasaṁ śarmmā dharmādhikaraṇika ma. ma. u. hariśarmmā, dighoyasaṁ jayadatta suta dharmādhikaraṇika bhaṭṭajīve, dharmādhikaraṇika ma. ma. (23/010) narasiṃha, dharmādhikaraṇika mahomahopādhyāya gadāghara, dharmādhikaraṇika vāṭū, naivaṃdhika-naivaṃdhika vīreśvara, naivaṃdhikadhīreśvara, mudrāhastaka guṇīśva, suta ma. ma. ābho esuta, mudrāhastaka kula chetropāryaka rāula, gaḍhabelaumca saṁ mudrāhastaka guṇīśvara, mudrāhastaka lakṣapati, mudrāhastaka lakṣmīdatta

The scientist Aryabhata, 476–550.

An entry concerning Aryabhata in the *pañjī* reads, with its recorded numerical reference (27) (34/08): a genealogical sequence beginning with Mahipati and Pitambar, then Damu, Trinayan Bhatta, Aryabhata, Udayabhatta, Vijayabhatta, Sulochan Bhatta (Sunayan Bhatta), Bhatta, Dharmajati Mishra, Dharajati Mishra, Brahmajari Mishra, Tripurajati Mishra, Vidhujati Mishra, Ajay Singh, Vijay Singh, Adivaraha, Mahavaraha, Duryodhan Singh and Sodhar Jaysingh; it ends by describing the learned Narasimha as accomplished in the great science of arms. The palm leaf is indistinct, and the name may also be read *Adibhatta*. In Aryabhata's own writings the only relevant statement is that he is expounding knowledge at Kusumapura (Patna). Most manuscripts of Aryabhata's *Āryabhaṭīya* have been found in Kerala. Nevertheless, the chronological coincidence connects the *pañjī*'s Adibhatta/Aryabhata with the author of the *Āryabhaṭīya*.

Genealogical Entry — Original Transcription

पञ्जीमे आर्यभट्टक विवरण- (२७) (३४/०८) महिपतिय: मंगरौनी माण्डैर सै पीताम्ब र सुत दामू दौ माण्ड्र सै वीजी त्रिनयनभट्ट: ए सुतो आर्यभट्ट: ए सुतो उदयभट्ट: ए सुतो विजयभट्ट ए सुतो सुलोचनभट (सुनयनभट्ट) ए सुतो भट्ट ए सुतो धर्मजटीमिश्र ए सुतो धाराजटी मिश्र ए सुतोब्रह्मजरी मिश्र ए सुतो त्रिपुरजटी मिश्र ए सुत विघुजटी मिश्र ए सुतो अजयसिंह: ए सुतो विजयसिंह: ए सुतो ए सुतो आदिवराह: ए सुतो महोवराह: ए सुतो दुर्योधन सिंह: ए सुतो सोढ़र जयसिंहर्काचार्यास्त्रस महास्त्र विद्या पारङगत महामहोपाध्या य: नरसिंह: । । तालपत्र अस्पष्ट अछि आ आदिभट्ट: सेहो पढ़ल जा सकैए, आर्यभट्टक अपन रचनामे मात्र एतबे चर्चा भेटैत अछि जे ओ कुसुमपुर (पटना) मे ज्ञानक वर्णन कऽ रहल छथि, अर्यभट्टक आर्यभटीयक अधिकांश पाण्डुलिपि केरलमे भेटल अछि। मुदा कालक समानता पञ्जीक आदिभट्ट/ आर्यभट्ट कैं आर्यभटीयक आर्यभटसँ मेल करबैत अछि।

Genealogical Entry — Roman Transliteration

pañjīme āryabhaṭṭaka vivaraṇa- (27) (34/08) mahipatiya: maṃgaraunī māṇḍaira sai pītāmba ra suta dāmū dau māṇḍra sai vījī trinayanabhaṭṭa: e suto āryabhaṭṭa: e suto udayabhaṭṭa: e suto vijayabhaṭṭa e suto sulocanabhaṭa (sunayanabhaṭṭa) e suto bhaṭṭa e suto dharmajaṭīmiśra e suto dhārājaṭī miśra e sutobrahmajarī miśra e suto tripurajaṭī miśra e suta vighujaṭī miśra e suto ajayasiṃha: e suto vijayasiṃha: e suto e suto ādivarāha: e suto mahovarāha: e suto duryodhana siṃha: e suto soḍhara jayasiṃharkācāryāstrasa mahāstra vidyā pāraṅagata mahāmahopādhyā ya: narasiṃha: . . tālapatra aspaṣṭa achi ā ādibhaṭṭaḥ seho paḍhala jā sakaie, āryabhaṭṭaka apana racanāme mātra etabe carcā bheṭaita achi je o kusumapura (paṭanā) me jñānaka varṇana ka' rahala chathi, aryabhaṭṭaka āryabhaṭīyaka adhikāṃśa pāṇḍulipi keralame bheṭala achi. mudā kālaka samānatā pañjīka ādibhaṭṭa/ āryabhaṭṭa kem̐ āryabhaṭīyaka āryabhaṭasam̐ mela karabaita achi.

Mahamahopadhyaya Gonu Jha, 1050–1150

The registers describe Gonu Jha of Sonkariyam, Karamhe, as ‘Mahamahopadhyaya Dhurtaraja Gonu’. A calculation by generations (the Sonkariyam–Karamhe line of Gonu is now in its twenty-fourth generation) places his birth after Aryabhata (the Mandar–Kashyap line is in its thirty-ninth generation) and before Vidyapati (the Bisfi–Kashyap line is in its fourteenth generation), at about 1050 CE. Multiplying the generations in this manner by forty yields approximately 476 CE for Aryabhata and approximately 1350 CE for the Sanskrit–Avahaṭṭa poet Vidyapati Thakur, dates that agree with accepted history in the author’s account. A prince of Bharaura was Gonu Jha’s fellow villager; the boatman-hero of the folktale ‘Bahura Godhin Natua Dayal’ also belongs to this place. His shrine remains in Bharaura.

Maharaja Harisinghdev. He belonged to the Karnata dynasty of Mithila. In Jyotirishwar Thakur’s *Varṇaratnākara*, Harisinghdev figures as a patron or king. He was born in 1294 and ascended the throne in 1307. After defeat by Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq in 1324–25, he fled to Nepal. He is regarded as the formal founder of the *pañjī* system among Mithila’s Brahmins, Kayasthas and Kshatriyas. Gunakar Jha was first appointed for the Maithil Brahmins, Shankardatt for the Karna Kayasthas and Vijaydatt for the Kshatriyas. Under the inspiration of Harisinghdev, a descendant of Nanyadev, who, according to the cited chronogram ‘*nandaida śūnyaṃ śaśi śāka varṣe*’, founded the Karnata line in the year identified here as Shaka 1019, the scholars of Mithila resolved in Shaka 1248, or 1326 CE, to initiate the present form of *pañjī* administration. Later, a few intellectually self-indulgent persons secured an order from Maharaja Madhav Singh of Mithila in 1760 to have genealogists prepare branch books (*śākhā-pustaka*). After this, a new Brahmin subcaste called ‘Shrotriya’ emerged in Mithila, supposedly in a period sometimes described in the registers as Shaka 1600 (1678 CE), but actually, the author argues, around 1800, after Madhav Singh.

Minister Ganeshwar. A minister of the Karnata ruler Harisinghdev of Mithila. *Sugatisopāna* describes Mithila’s constitutional history.

Maharaja Nanyadev. Founder of the Karnata dynasty of Mithila in 1097 CE; he died in 1147. Malladev was the son of its founder Nanyadev. The Gandhavariya Rajputs of Mithila regard Malladev as their founding ancestor.

Maldwar. The five-*pravara* Naruar family of the Vatsa gotra from Karamhe: Raja Ramlochan Chaudhary of Maldwar, approximately 2,500 years earlier; Raja Durga Prasad Chaudhary.

Raja Buddhinath Chaudhary (Maldwar)—Kumar Vaidyanath Chaudhary.

Chhatrnath Chaudhary (Durgaganj)—Tanknath Chaudhary—Karmanath / Sheshnath / Rudranath.

Ek Chhali Maharani—Dr Madaneshwar Mishra.

Surgane Lauam: Parashara gotra.

The original village of Lauam lay between Basaithi and Purnia; it no longer exists.

The Shandilya-gotra line with its ancestral origin at Tilai-bar.

Baneli village—Agaru Rai; his son-in-law Pranpati of the Surgane–Lauam ancestral line; his son Samar Jha.

Approximately 1575–1625 (around the sixteenth century): he purchased a zamindari from the Delhi Sultanate, became Samar Chaudhary and later took the title Maharaja.

Two branches of Lauam:

Maharaja Krishnadev (Pahsara–Basaithi);

Maharaja Bhagirath of Sauria (between Katihar and Sonaili). One place was called Dandkhora, where criminals were punished by the Sauria branch.

Five generations later, the Pahsara–Basaithi succession runs Krishnadev—Devnarayan—Vir Narayan—Ramchandra Narayan (described by John Buchanan in the Purnia Gazetteer as the 'King of Purnia')—Indranarayan (who had no children). Queen Indravati (a name acquired in her marital household; her original name was Lilavati) died on 15 November 1803, at midday, in Purnia. For the expenses of the *śrāddha*, 5,000 rupees were received from the Purnia judge against a demand for 15,670 rupees, according to proceedings dated 29 November 1803 before the Board of Revenue at Fort William. Raja Rajendranarayan and Raja Mahendranarayan of the Sauria line were contemporaries of Indranarayan. Maharaja Indranarayan died in 1776; Queen Indravati ruled for the following twenty-seven years.

The Baneli estate: Ramnagar, Srinagar, Garh-Baneli, Sultanganj and Champanagar.

The Shyama temple; a stipend for studying Sanskrit in Banaras; Queen Chandravati of Koilakh (daughter-in-law of Raja Padmanand Singh and wife of Kumar Chandranand Singh)—Ramnagar.

Visheshwar Jha came from Baigani Nawada to Pahsara for employment. His son was Diwan Devanand, followed by Param-anand, a mansabdar of the Chaturdhari line. Through his evening *gāyatrī* observance he gradually came to acknowledge Samar Singh of Baneli. Dular Chaudhary,

later styled Singh of the Baneli estate, is called 'Chaudhary' by Buchanan and 'Singh' only once.

In 1680–1700, the Darbhanga estate and the battle of Kandarpi Ghat: Raja Narendra Singh stood between the Delhi Sultanate and the people. Accused of Brahmin-killing on the banks of the Bagmati at Samastipur, Narendra Singh was opposed by the Bari Brahmins, who were settled by the descendants of Maharaja Samar Singh of the Surgane–Lauam line of Purnia, specifically Maharaja Narnarayan of Pahsara–Basaithi east of the Kosi, from Forbesganj to Dandkhora in Katihar. They later returned to Darbhanga in the time of Madhav Singh.

The Baneli estate paid salaries to Khuddi Jha and Parameshwar Jha in the time of Ashutosh Mukherjee.

An honorific panegyric to the Darbhanga rulers occurs in the *pañjī*: '*vividha-virudāvalī-virājamāna mānonnatamāna pratijñā-pada … paraśurāma … nṛparāja mahograpratāpa mithilāṅkāra mahārājādhirāja Mādhava Siṃha Bahādura Kāmeśvara Siṃha*.'

Lakshmipati Mishra, the nine-*lakh* holder of Dhakjari and a Shandilya-gotra member of the Kodariye line, received a *pañjī*. He gave Rameshwar Singh a contribution of one and a half lakh rupees. The Chaudharys of Pindaruch, including Nityanand Chaudhary, also obtained genealogical registers.

Gunakar Jha. A contemporary of Harisinghdev in 1326 CE, from Tatail village. Ten generations later the family was in Kakraur, Madhubani district: Raghudev Jha—Anand Jha—Devanand, known as Chhoti Jha (a contemporary of Darbhanga's Madhav Singh and his order for the branch books, placed here around 1650)—Mitranand, known as Jhonti Jha—Gopinath Jha, known as Horil Jha—Harkhanand, known as Harkhi Jha. Then comes a *Dinkar* note from 159 years earlier, recording a birth at Rasadh near Banmankhi, Purnia: Bholanath, known as Bhikhiya Jha—Modanand Jha—the genealogist Vidyanand Jha, known as Mohanji. Their ancestral origin is Padua (Pandua), Mahindrapur; the gotra is Kashyap, with three *pravaras*.

'Khan'—the Kujilwar–Ullu ancestral line, Katyayana gotra.

Uteṛh. Before a marriage *siddhānta* is drawn up, the rights or eligibility of the bridegroom's and bride's families are examined, initially on the basis of their *mūla*, or ancestral line. Gotra and *pravara* are also examined to ensure that a marriage does not take place within the same gotra. The gotra can usually be determined from the *mūla*, although exceptions exist. For example, Brahmpura includes seven gotras, among them Kashyap, Gautam, Vatsa and Vasishtha; in Karamha the Gaul branch is Shandilya,

while the others belong to the Vatsa gotra. Marriage between the two Karamha branches is therefore possible.

Chanda Jha—Mandar Rajoura.

'*Rāmo 'vetti nalo 'vetti vetti rājā purūravā.*'

'*Alarkasya dhanaṃ prāpya nānyadevo nṛpo bhaviṣyati.*'

Nanyadev arrived on horseback, tired and thirsty. He tied his horse beneath a tree and began cutting fodder for it. A cobra appeared with its hood raised and something written upon it, but Nanyadev could not read the language of Mithila. Kameshwar Thakur, who lived in that village, read it out and told him that he was to be King Nanyadev of Mithila.

Harisinghdev handed the kingdom over in writing to Chandeswar, a descendant of Kameshwar Thakur, and fled. Soldiers pursued Chandeswar. He threw water upon one man, who remained standing where he was; he flung water at another, who became blind. Hence the name Andhara Tharhi.

From *Varṣakṛtya*: 'When Bihula came, she spread it out;

when Sama departed, she folded it away.'

Rules concerning rights in the genealogical registers: the Dhaka poet, a grandson of Ayachi Mishra, received a jagir in Dhaka. A debate took place between the Tantric Halli Jha and Shiv Kumar Shastri. By means of the Tantric technique called *pratyāhāra-vāk*, Halli rendered Shiv Kumar Shastri speechless.

Taskar Keshav. The Mangrauni–Naraune–Sulhani line of the Parashara gotra and Khagnath Jha of the Mandar–Sihaul ancestral line, Kashyap gotra, lived at Jamsam. A girl was selected in marriage for Maharaja Lakshmishwar Singh. A pond was excavated and a temple built in the village, for how could a king worship in someone else's temple? Keshav Jha took the girl back to the village. While a *dhoti* was being dyed, a man who came to investigate was seized and made to officiate at the giving away of the bride. What could the king do thereafter? He summoned the genealogist and had the epithet *Taskar* ('thief') prefixed to Keshav's name. Khagnath Jha's and Shrikant Jha's records show that, had the Shrotriya Taskar Keshav married there, he would have retained the Shrotriya rank. The *pañjī* and water both flow downwards; the former first rank across the western bank no longer exists.

There are forty-three ancestral lines (*mūla*) in the Shandilya gotra, forty in Vatsa, twenty-seven in Kashyap, seven in Savarna, five in Katyayana, seven in Parashara, five in Bharadwaj, and three in Garga.

When the Sun occupies Leo, from 16 August to 16 September, the sunlight is at its fiercest for drying anything.

The Mandar-line book written by Pandit Raghudev Jha bears dates from the last decade of the seventeenth century and the first decade of the eighteenth. The branch book written by his grandson, Pandit Devanand Jha, known as Chhoti, dates from 1760–1776. The records are on palm leaves.

Pandit Bhikhiya Jha's branch book was written by Pandit Domai Mishra of the Hariamb ancestral line, resident at Koilakh. The branch book associated with Pandit Harshanand Jha was written by Pandit Mitranand Jha, known as Jhonti. Other branch books include the one associated with Pandit Jhulanand Jha (brother of Bhikhiya Jha), and that of Pandit Modanand Jha, which incorporates material associated with his maternal uncle Pandit Lutan Jha and his maternal cousin Pandit Nirsu Jha; these were written at Saurath between 1925 and 1935. These branch books contain *gotra-pañjī*, describing gotras and ancestral lines; *patra-pañjī*, giving descendants and ancestral villages and thereby revealing changes of residence; and *dūṣaṇa-pañjī*, recording alleged defects within a lineage, which can also serve as evidence against orthodoxy. The volumes also disclose the titles in use during their respective periods.

Technical vocabulary. Before recording a lineage, the *pañjī* gives its ancestral line or *mūla*, followed by the name of the individual. This is followed by a reference to the man's male offspring, written as *sutaḥ*, *sutau* or *sutāḥ*. Where a man has no sons but has a daughter, the entry may use *sutā* or *sutāś ca*. After *sutaḥ*, *sutau* or *sutā* appears the name of the child, then the ancestral village and line of the child's maternal grandfather. In some instances the original village is not recorded. Later in the book the *mūla* may be given only through an initial and a dot, without the word *saṃ* ('from'), because a reader progressing through the records will already recognise the line. In particular cases the father-in-law's name is preceded by the name of his father or even his grandfather. After the father-in-law's name the abbreviation *dau.* appears: it indicates that the person whose name carries *dau.* is the daughter's son, or *dauhitra*, of the person appearing before the name that follows *sutaḥ*, *sutau* or *sutā*; in other words, that earlier person is the maternal grandfather of the child or children indicated. Thereafter the father-in-law is identified with his *mūla*, and the word *dauhitra* appears after the name, abbreviated *ddau.* One must also understand that a branch book does not have a separate subject index: subject references are integrated with its genealogical contents.

38. The Influence of English Literature on the Maithili Novel

Abstract

The beginnings of the novel. *Bana Bhatta's Kādambarī opens with a description of King Shudraka's city of Vidisha. An exceedingly beautiful girl of the Chandala community comes to court with a learned parrot named Vaishampayana, and the parrot's story begins. In the Chandala settlement of Pakkana there are neither beggars nor thieves; even its king, Vyaghradev, makes rope with his own hands.*

Keywords: Novel · English Literature · Influence · Literary Criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Abstract

This chapter offers a study in dramatic criticism on "The Influence of English Literature on the Maithili Novel". Maithili novels and the influence of English literature are its central subjects. Using examples, quotations and arguments in the original material, it examines dramatic texts, character organisation, stage structure and cultural contexts, so that readers may understand both the critical structure of the topic and its wider setting.

The beginnings of the novel. Bana Bhatta's *Kādambarī* begins with a description of King Shudraka's city of Vidisha. An exceedingly beautiful Chandala girl arrives at court with a learned parrot named Vaishampayana, and the parrot's story begins. In the Chandala settlement of Pakkana there are neither beggars nor thieves; even its king, Vyaghradev, plaits rope himself. Because of the title of this Sanskrit novel, the novel is called *kādambarī* in Marathi. Despite the bourgeois beginnings of the novel, the genre is sufficiently complex to put a writer's talent to a thorough test. Precisely because of its bourgeois origins, although Cervantes's *Don Quixote* had appeared at the beginning of the seventeenth century, the novel acquired a serious form only shortly before the nineteenth century. Debate, dispute and dialogue within a novel generate the essay; the characters of young men and women bring in romantic narrative; people and geography supply historical description; and then the stories of good and bad characters emerge. At times the novel makes the reader laugh, and at others it instructs. Marxism advocates the representation of social reality in the novel. Freud regards every human being as mysterious. He selects the literary work for an analysis of its author, while neo-Freudian thought emphasises cultural rather than biological factors. New Criticism rests upon close attention to the work itself. Life experience, too, is one-sided, and within this situation the author creates a world to satisfy suppressed desires, in which the reader moves along the boundary between reality and imagination.

Theories of the English novel. Postmodernism, existentialism and humanism are all philosophical tendencies. In earlier times philosophy

encompassed science, history, society and politics, economics, aesthetics and the study of language. As the branches of science and the arts became specialised—science in particular—the relation of philosophy to mathematics and science narrowed toward mathematical logic. Philosophical methods of induction and deduction developed in the direction of analytic method. Marx, who seemed like a divine intervention for the poor throughout the world, made dialectics the basis of his explanation.

Origins and development of the English novel. In *The Pilgrim's Progress*, the author narrates the journey of the principal character and the struggles and moments of enthusiasm encountered along that journey.

In *Robinson Crusoe*, Daniel Defoe describes his protagonist's adventurous sea voyage.

Samuel Richardson's *Pamela* gave the English novel a more clearly defined generic form.

Aphra Behn's *Oroonoko* has a Black enslaved man as its protagonist, while her *Love-Letters Between a Nobleman and His Sister* recounts an aristocratic love story.

In *Tom Jones*, Henry Fielding criticises feudalism and portrays the distortions of society.

In *The Portrait of a Lady*, Henry James subordinates life to artistic presentation.

In *Clarissa*, Richardson descends into the layers of human psychology.

The characters in Joseph Conrad's *The Shadow-Line* reflect on the one-sidedness of their attitudes towards society and life.

The characters in D. H. Lawrence's *Lady Chatterley's Lover* blame the civilisation produced by culture for human distortion.

Rudyard Kipling's *Kim* seeks a justification for European imperialism, treating European civilisation as superior.

E. M. Forster's *A Passage to India*, by contrast, explores the relationship between rulers and the ruled.

Origins and development of the Maithili novel. Harimohan Jha's *Kanyādāna* and *Dvirāgamana* bring many features of Mithila's social order into view. In a mode reminiscent of the modern English novel, they portray women's education and uncritical Westernisation through humour.

Yatri's *Balchanma* takes the form of the autobiographical testimony of Balchanma, a member of the Yadav community. Economic problems form

its central subject. The narrative follows his development from a domestic attendant to a man who gives his life for peasants' rights. Yatri Ji clearly inclined towards the Communist Party rather than the Congress and other parties. In contrast to the economic preoccupations of *Balchanma*, *Pāro* seeks a social objective. After some time, readers may regard this novel as pure fiction, because the next generation will hardly believe that such a cruel social order could ever have existed among human beings. Its importance will then increase, for it carries the responsibility of preserving those institutions as a historical record. Yet when Yatri Ji wrote about these problems they were living realities, and the novel intervened meaningfully in them.

Ramanand Renu's *Dūdh-Phūl* places a neglected section of society in the foreground and gives it an artistic presentation.

Lalit's *Pṛthvīputra* likewise brings society's neglected people into view. The novel also points to the economic problems of peasant life.

Lili Ray's *Paṭākṣepa* narrates the rise of left-wing class struggle and its subsequent suppression. It offers a model of the writer's immediate engagement with the problems of the country.

Dhumketu's *Moṛ Par* likewise recounts social and economic difficulties from a left-wing perspective, using flashback.

Saketanand's *Sarvasvānta* is a narrative of floods, government policies and relief operations.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal's *Maulāil Gāchak Phūl* concerns the village, migration away from the village, and solutions for restoring life to a decaying social order.

Chaturanan Mishra's *Kalā* attacks a decayed social system through its heroine, Kaladai.

Shefalika Verma's *Nāgphāṃs* moves across English soil. Will the current and the frontier ever meet in this life? Will some miracle take place?

In conclusion. If we look closely, it appears that English novelists attempt to carry the doctrines and perspectives of their age into their works. Yet, in moving from theory to practice, certain distinctive qualities arise of their own accord. The same holds for the Maithili novel. Whether we read Ramanand Renu or Shefalika Verma, the point is clearly visible in the technique. The sharpness with which Lili Ray's pen describes the events, society and politics around her is remarkable: it goes a step beyond the English novels. Lalit, Yatri and Dhumketu confront economic and social problems, concealing none of the relevant facts. Saketanand confronts the problem of floods. In his distinctive style, Harimohan Jha lets the current of English literature flow through his writing, even bringing it into the

syllabus that his hero prescribes for the heroine's education.

Chaturanan Mishra and Jagdish Prasad Mandal have practical connections with the Communist movement, including party-level activity. Yet after reading both their novels, I have no hesitation in saying that, while Yatri and Dhumketu seem to prop up their novels with the crutch of Marxism, these two novelists feel no such need. The true meaning of Marxism can be found in their writings. They do not mention a political party or name an ideology, but the real substance of dialectical materialism is recognisable there: faith in the importance of life and the use of a dialectical method. This is possible only when a writer has studied Marxism profoundly, including *Das Kapital*.

The future of the Maithili novel. In every living language the novel is the genre in which the greatest number of works are written, yet in Maithili novels are produced least frequently. As the number of younger writers entering Maithili literature after studying English education and literature increases, Maithili literature will be able to develop its social, economic, political and cultural insight. Veena Thakur's *Bhāratī*, Asha Mishra's *Ucāṭ*, and Kedarnath Chaudhary's *Camelī Rānī*, *Māhur* and *Karār* confirm this perspective.

39. Reflections on Words: Siddha Sarahapada, the Tibetan Script, Computers and Maithili

Abstract

Apart from Devanagari, the scripts of the languages of northern India, Nepal and the south (with the exception of Tamil) employ alphabets comprising vowels and the consonantal groups ka, ca, ṭa, ta and pa, together with ya, ra, la, va, śa, sa and ha. Sanskrit has a further sign for gvāṅ: the Chāndogya tradition does not pronounce it, whereas the Vājasaneyī tradition makes extensive use of it—for example, where the former says सभूमि*, the latter says* सभूमीग्वंङ्. *It occurs in both short and long forms. Mithilākṣara also uses at least six distinct forms for the expression siddhir astu.*

Keywords: words · reflection · Siddha · Sarahapada · Tibetan · script · computers · critical theory

Apart from Devanagari, the scripts of the languages of northern India, Nepal and the south (with the exception of Tamil) employ alphabets comprising vowels and the consonantal groups ka, ca, ṭa, ta and pa, together with ya, ra, la, va, śa, sa and ha. Sanskrit has another letter for gvāṅ: the Chāndogya tradition does not pronounce it, whereas the Vājasaneyī tradition uses it freely—for example, Chāndogya will say सभूमि, while Vājasaneyī will say सभूमीग्वंङ्. It has both short and long forms. At least six different signs are employed for siddhir astu in Mithilākṣara. Vedic Sanskrit uses udātta, anudātta and svarita accents (respectively क॑, क॒ and क॑े); Marathi also uses ळ and the half-form ऴ. Maithili uses ऽ (bikārī, or avagraha) as Sanskrit does. Nowadays, for ease of typing, one also sees द' in place of दऽ, but this is evidence of a technical deficiency in the font concerned. An avagraha is not, however, needed after the ā-vowel sign.

Just as Persian has alif, be and se, and the Roman alphabet has A, B and C, the alphabets of Indian languages are, broadly speaking, similar in their arrangement despite differences of script.

Letters are of two kinds, vowels and consonants. Their total number is sixty-four: twenty-two vowels and forty-two consonants.

Let us begin with the vowels. A vowel is a sound that can be pronounced without relying upon the pronunciation of another letter.

Vowels have three varieties: short (hrasva), long (dīrgha) and protracted (pluta). A short vowel takes one mātrā of time to pronounce, a long vowel takes two, and a protracted vowel takes three.

The fundamental vowels are: अ इ उ ऋ ऌ.

Pre-Pāṇinian teachers called these samānākṣara.

The long compound vowels are: ए ऐ ओ औ.

Pre-Pāṇinian teachers called these sandhyakṣara.

The vowel ऌ has no long form, and the compound vowels have no short forms.

The short, long (आ ई ऊ ॠ) and protracted (आ३ ई३ ऊ३ ॠ३) forms of अ इ उ ऋ together make twelve letters. ऌ has two varieties, short and protracted (ऌ३), making two more. ए ऐ ओ औ are four long compound vowels, each with a protracted form (ए३ ऐ३ ओ३ औ३); these make another eight. The total is therefore twenty-two vowels.

All twenty-two vowels have three Vedic accentual forms: udātta, anudātta and svarita.

The a-class sounds articulated from a higher position, such as the palate, possess the quality of udātta and are therefore so called.

Sounds produced from a lower position are anudātta; when the first part of an a-class vowel is pronounced with udātta and its second part with anudātta, the result is svarita.

Vowels are also divided into nasalised, as in अँ, and non-nasalised, as in अ.

"Dattena nirvṛttaḥ kūpo dāttaḥ": a well constructed by a man named Datta on the northern bank of the Vipāṭ–Vyāsa is here called dātta. Because it takes the suffix añ, dātta has the initial udātta accent; if it had taken the suffix aṇ, the accent would have fallen at the end, upon the suffix. Although the visible word-form does not change, its accent does. This establishes that ordinary agricultural communities too pronounced words with their proper accents.

Svarita may also be understood in another way: the final vowel is sounded again with heightened pitch.

We now turn to consonants.

There are forty-two consonants.

क् ख् ग् घ् ङ्

च् छ् ज् झ् ञ्

ट् ठ् ड् ढ् ण्

त् थ् द् ध् न्

प् फ् ब् भ् म्

य् र् ल् व्

श् ष् स्

ह्

य्, व् and ल् also occur in nasalised forms—यँ, वँ, लँ—as well as in non-nasalised forms.

In addition there are two further consonantal signs: anusvāra and visarjanīya, or visarga.

Both occur after vowels.

Visarjanīya is not an independent original letter but a modification of स् or र्. With differences of sound and form, it has two varieties, jihvāmūlīya and upadhmānīya. The former occurs only before क and ख; the latter only before प and फ.

Anusvāra, visarjanīya, jihvāmūlīya and upadhmānīya are called ayogavāha.

Beyond these letters, there are four further sounds called yama.

कुँ खुँ गुँ घुँ (as in पलिक् क्नी, चख ख्नुतः, अग् ग्निः and घ् घ्नन्ति).

When a fifth consonant of a class follows, the intervening sound resembling the preceding consonant is called yama.

Yama too belongs to the ayogavāha class.

अ, आ, the ka-class, uncombined ह and visarjanīya are articulated in the throat.

इ, ई, the ca-class, य and श are articulated at the palate.

ऋ, ॠ, the ṭa-class, र and ष are articulated at the roof of the mouth (mūrdhan).

ऌ, the ta-class, ल and स are articulated with the teeth.

उ, ऊ, the pa-class and upadhmānīya are articulated with the lips.

व is articulated with the upper teeth and the lower lip.

ए and ऐ are articulated in the throat and at the palate.

ओ and औ are articulated in the throat and with the lips.

In pronouncing य, र, ल and व, the tip and other parts of the tongue do not make complete contact with the palate and other articulatory locations as they do for other consonants. Nor do these sounds involve the friction at the palate and other places that occurs with श्, ष्, स् and ह्.

The letters from क to म are stops (or plosives: the tip of the tongue blocks and then releases the airflow); those from र to व are approximants (antaḥstha), and those from ष to ह are fricatives.

The fifth member of each consonantal class is called nasal because, while its other place of articulation remains the same, it is also produced through the nose: air passes out through both nose and mouth.

Anusvāra and yama are pronounced only through the nose and are accordingly called nāsikya: the oral passage remains closed and the air escapes through the nasal passage. Anusvāra should not be pronounced as न् or म्.

When we desire to speak, intention stimulates the digestive fire (jaṭharāgni). Air near the navel rises forcefully towards the head; after being checked by the tip and other parts of the tongue, it rubs against the palate and other parts of the mouth, and letters are produced. Through vibration the air acquires resonance (nāda), and when this resonant air reaches the mouth the sound is called voiced (ghoṣavān). When it reaches the breath without resonance, it is called unvoiced (aghoṣavān).

Letters whose nature is that of breath are “unvoiced” (aghoṣa), while those whose nature is resonance are “voiced” (ghoṣavān). Sounds produced with little breath are alpaprāṇa (unaspirated); those produced with an abundance of breath are mahāprāṇa (aspirated).

In each of the ka, ca, ṭa, ta and pa classes, the first, third and fifth members are alpaprāṇa; the second and fourth are mahāprāṇa. Likewise, the first and second members are unvoiced, while the third, fourth and fifth are voiced. य, र, ल and व are voiced and unaspirated. श, ष and स are unvoiced and aspirated; ह is voiced and aspirated. Vowels are unaspirated and may carry udātta, anudātta or svarita accent.

Journey to Sikkim (Travelogue)

Siddha Sarahapada and the Tibetan Script: When I placed a photograph of Siddha Sarahapada in the design of Radhakrishna Chaudhary's book, my attention was drawn almost involuntarily to the Tibetan writing beneath it—a script quite different from Chinese and bearing affinities with Sikkim's Lepcha and Limbu (Subba language). Sikkim's Chogyal kings were Buddhists. They and their descendants are called Sikkimese, such as

the Demjongpa; they speak the Bhutia language. But when Bhutia speakers came to the royal court from Bhutan, Tibet and elsewhere, a distinction arose between "Sikkimese" and "Bhutia" to differentiate the two communities. Broadly speaking, if you ask people in Sikkim, they will call all these non-Nepali languages, including Tibetan, "Bhutia."

In Gangtok, Bharat Subba says he is a pure Nepali and that the Subba language (Limbu) has its own script. He saw his grandfather reading it, but does not himself know the language. Lepcha, however, has a distinct language and script of its own.

Dinesh Kharka is a Nepali Brahmin. He says that in Sikkim there is no restriction on studying Nepali, Bhutia or Lepcha. The Lepchas are the indigenous people of the region. Learning Bhutia makes it easier to find employment in the tourism department. He also says that the Nepali spoken in Nepal differs from that spoken here. We say laṛkā–laṛkī for boy and girl, whereas in Nepal the words are bābū and nānī. Kānchhā and kānchhī refer to the youngest boy and girl (the youngest bābū and nānī) in a household. Urgen Bhutia's mother is Nepali, so he does not know Bhutia very well. He lives not in Sikkim but in Darjeeling, in West Bengal, where the educational system is ill-disposed towards languages other than Bengali and Nepali. It is like Bihar's education system, which is intolerant of languages other than Hindi; thus Bhutia may be regarded as virtually extinguished there. Sikkim, by contrast, is liberal in this respect.

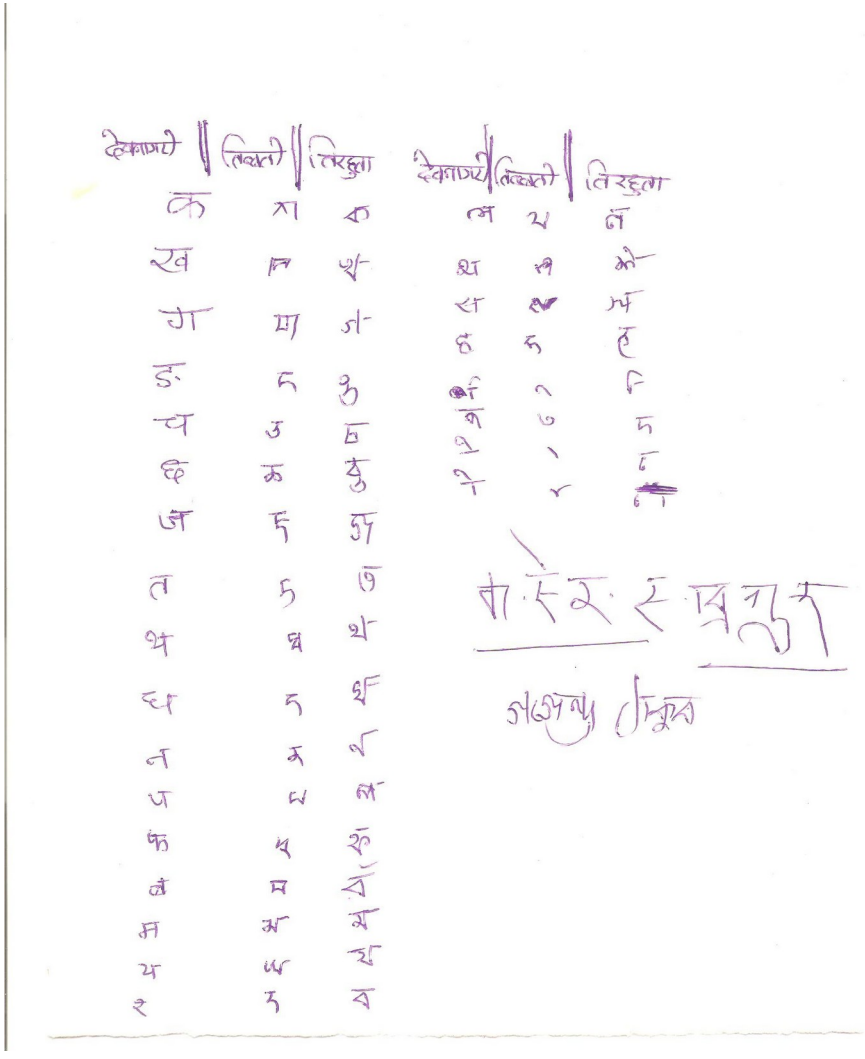
At first Chhiring tells me that he speaks Bhutia, which he calls Tibetan. Later, on the road to Lachung in North Sikkim, he stops somewhere to eat. A woman there says that she is Tibetan. A lama who has come from Dehradun is staying with her, and he teaches me the Tibetan script. Lachen lies beside Lachung. On seeing a yak, Chhiring now explains the actual distinction. Sheep-herders are called dongpa, he says. People from Lachung take the surname Lachungpa; he himself is from neighbouring Lachen and is therefore called Chhiring Lachenpa. Not all Lachungpas are dongpas, but most dongpas bear the surname Lachungpa. The Dengjongpas live in Gangtok and engage in trade. Tok means "on a height," as in the place called Ganesh Tok. He says the languages of the Lachenpas and Lachungpas differ from Bhutia. They are Buddhists. The difference between Lachungpa and Lachenpa speech is one of shortened and lengthened forms. The road beyond Lachung goes as far as Zero, where trees and vegetation disappear and oxygen becomes scarce; yet snow may be seen there until May and early June. Along the roads and near the monasteries one sees prayer wheels inscribed with mantras in Tibetan. On the way to a monastery, a child monk prevents us from turning a prayer wheel, explaining that it should be turned on the return journey, and then only clockwise. Along the roads one finds 108 flags bearing mantras in

Tibetan. When all of them are white, they have been raised by relatives in memory of someone who has died; when they are of different colours, they have been flown for the pacification of planetary influences. Chhiring says that the wind cannot bring a flag down while the mantra written on it remains legible; only when it has become soiled and faded can the wind carry it away.

At Tsangu Lake on the way to Nathu La ("the pass of the listening ears"), in eastern Sikkim, I meet Pradeep Tamang with a yak. His village lies behind the mountain. He says that Tibetan and Bhutia are different languages, though they also share similarities. Nathu La is at an altitude of fourteen thousand feet, and the pass has been used for trade between India and Tibet since ancient times. Here, as at Zero, one feels the shortage of oxygen. Tibetan traders still bring silk through this pass to the covered market at Sherathang village and take biscuits and Dalda back in exchange.

In Gangtok, Dinesh Tamang says he is a Nepali Buddhist, though he was born in Bengal. He believes the demand for Gorkhaland will not be accepted, because accepting it would also entail accepting demands for separate provinces in the Kantapuri (Kamatapuri) area of Jalpaiguri and in Cooch Behar. He regards the languages of both places as distinct from Bengali, calling them "Bāyā Bengali" (Bāhe Bengali). He also maintained that, besides their language, Bāhe Bengalis differ physically from Bengalis; indeed, he said, if the truth be told, these Bāhe Bengalis were the original Bengalis.

The accompanying illustration shows the method of learning the Tibetan script.



Computers and Maithili

Google Translator Toolkit has now given Maithili a place both as a source language and as a target language. See: http: //support.google.com/translate/toolkit/bin/answer.py?hl=en&answer=147837

And: http: //translate.google.com/toolkit/list?hl=en#translations/active

Following Videha's objection, Google has accepted that there is no language called "Bihari." Videha had already established "Wikipedia Maithili," and Wikipedia had likewise accepted earlier that no such language as "Bihari" exists.

Google Maithili: Google Language Tool—

http: //www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseProject

Contribute to Google Translate, and when revising an existing translation explain in the "reason" field (in English) that there is no language called "Bihari." Translate at the following link after logging in through a Google account.

http: //www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseActivity?project=gws&langcode=bh

Keep checking this link for the availability of Maithili: http: //www.google.co.in/language_tools?hl=en

[Notice 1. The applications submitted by Anshuman Pandey to encode both Kaithi and Mithilākṣara in the Universal Character Set (Unicode) have been approved. The process of creating Unicode fonts for the two scripts has now entered the queue; when their turn comes, work on the basic fonts will begin. The basic font for Mithilākṣara will be named Tirhuta (just as the basic Devanagari font is called Mangal and the basic Bengali font Vrinda). The Mithilākṣara application was submitted in a third revised version. Both the second and third submissions discussed Videha's contribution in detail, as follows: "Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22; Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http: //www.videha.co.in/." "Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and corresponded at length about Maithili, offered valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and provided feedback regarding requirements for the encoding of Maithili in the UCS."—Anshuman Pandey.]

Notice 2. Google Maithili: Google Language Tool—

Notice 3. Wikipedia Maithili

Videha members have translated 2,600 MediaWiki messages from English into Maithili. Now go to http: //translatewiki.net/wiki/Special:Translate?task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai and use the Group drop-down menu to translate untranslated messages. If you are not yet a Wikipedia translator, request permission to translate into Maithili at http: //translatewiki.net/wiki/Project:Translator. Before doing so, log in at the upper right (or create an account if you have none), select Maithili as your language in Preferences, click the link to your user account and create your user page. After some time you will receive permission to translate. You can then begin translating.

http: //translatewiki.net/wiki/Project:Translator

http:
//meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Requests_for_new_languages/Wikipedia_Maithili

http: //translatewiki.net/wiki/Special:Translate?task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai

http: //incubator.wikimedia.org/wiki/Wp/mai

http: //translatewiki.net/wiki/MediaWiki:Mainpage/mai

In Videha's third issue (1 February 2008), I had announced: "There were articles about Maithili on Wikipedia, but none written in Maithili, because Maithili Wikipedia had not yet been approved. I had been working on this for a long time, and I am pleased to announce that on 27 January 2008 permission was granted to start a wiki for the (Maithili) language. Yet at least five people from different places must work regularly as its editors before the project can receive final approval." More than three years have now passed and all the preliminary requirements for Maithili Wikipedia have been fulfilled. Wikipedia's Language Committee has now understood that Maithili is not a language "known by the name Bihari," and that a separate Wikipedia is needed for it. Gerard M. of Wikipedia writes (http: //ultimategerardm.blogspot.com/2011/05/bihari-wikipedia-is-actually-written-in.html):

"This information about Maithili and its relationship to the Bihari language group was provided by Umesh Mandal. Umesh is working on the localisation project for Maithili on Wikipedia ... The Language Committee is trying to determine whether Maithili can be placed under the Bihari language group ... But Umesh's answer has now made it entirely clear that the answer is 'no'."

When Ramvilas Sharma attempted to treat Maithili as a dialect of Hindi in his essay "Maithili aur Hindi," published in the Hindi monthly Pāṭal, edited by Ramdayal Pandey, Yatri Ji opposed him in an article in Hindi. Yatri was then forty-three years old (Āryāvarta, 14/21 February 1954). Rajmohan Jha's Maithili translation of that article appeared in the second issue of Ārambh. Umesh Mandal's successful intervention has an added distinction because he is still only thirty. What does it reveal that, although Maithils work in computer science in Hyderabad, Bangalore and as far away as Seattle, this protest or correction was made not by them but by a young lover of Maithili living in a remote part of Mithila?

Through fieldwork, Umesh Mandal has also digitised audio and video recordings of songs sung by people of every caste and religion in Mithila; these are available in the Videha archive.

Hindi has problems of its own. The language originally spoken in the bazaar (the Urdu bazaar) became Urdu when written in the Persian script, and Hindi when written in Devanagari. Historical references to Hindi therefore appeared later; looked at in this way, Hindi had not even a scrap of land of its own. But if we move forward from Vedic Sanskrit, and Hindi refuses to recognise Braj, Awadhi or Maithili as part of its older inheritance, what would constitute its early literature? Hence one cannot prevent Vidyapati, Mirabai, Kabir and Tulsidas from being taught within the history of Hindi's older literature; nor is there any need for an uproar when Vidyapati is called a Hindi poet. Maithili will survive only if it is strong in its own home. Hindi-speaking scholars acknowledge Vidyapati as a Maithili poet. Braj and Awadhi, which were literary languages before Hindi, have become dialects of Hindi, and literary creation in them has now ceased.

Maithili speakers will not let their language die. Authentic writers emerging from among native speakers will safeguard Maithili's independent existence through their authentic Maithili. The fear comes instead from the class that writes in pursuit of prizes while avoiding the language's culture and genuine vocabulary, that remains distant from ordinary people and their culture, yet has seized control of the official literary establishment.

TIRHUTA UNICODE

See the final UNICODE Mithilakshara Application (May 5, 2011) by Sh. Anshuman Pandey http: //std.dkuug.dk/JTC1/SC2/WG2/docs/n4035.pdf at Page 23 the Videha 80th issue (Tirhuta version) is attached "Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22" and at Page 12 Videha is included in References: Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http: //www.videha.co.in/. The role of Videha's editor is acknowledged on Page 12: "Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and corresponded at length about Maithili, offered

valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and provided feedback regarding requirements for the encoding of Maithili in the UCS."]

Top of Form

40. Workshop in Storytelling and Story Writing (With Special Reference to Children's Stories)

Abstract

Maithili has a very old tradition of storytelling, especially the telling of children's stories to the young. Folk ballads performed night after night or throughout the day; shorter versions adapted to children's minds; grandmothers' tales combining prose and verse and extending over one or several nights; and other folktales told by grandmothers, mothers, grandfathers and fathers are its diverse forms, which have captivated the boys and girls of Mithila.

Keywords: storytelling · reading · writing · workshop · children · children's stories · special reference

1

Maithili has a very old tradition of storytelling, especially storytelling for young children. Folk ballads performed night after night or throughout the day; shorter versions adapted to children's minds; grandmothers' tales combining prose and verse and extending over one or several nights; and other folktales told by grandmothers, mothers, grandfathers and fathers are its various forms, which have captivated the children of Mithila. In contrast, knowledge of the stories associated with Saptā-Ḍorā, Madhushrāvani and Bihulā has largely been confined to girls. Even when they live in the same household, very few boys dare take part in these storytelling sessions for fear of being labelled maugiyāhā (effeminate).

Songs, proverbs and games also occur within the telling of stories. Children themselves recite and sing the stories of their games while continuing to play; no grandmother may enter, and no father or grandfather can intrude upon the boys' and girls' games.

2

Despite such a rich tradition of storytelling, why has Maithili children's fiction failed, or why is it still failing? Except for Lili Ray, I do not hesitate to say that Maithili children's literature patronised by the Sahitya Akademi—whether through publication or awards—scarcely exists as children's literature at all. If you lack talent, translate; but sponsored translations are of such a standard that even a child's father cannot get through a single paragraph without grimacing at the language.

3

The Sahitya Akademi published an anthology of children's stories drawn from twenty-four languages. Maithili too has its quota, so how could the children's stories of Ramdev Jha and his son fail to appear? When a drama

anthology is due, a play is promptly produced on the same pattern. Lili Ray's story, however, is beautiful. Such practices bring Maithili into disrepute: the world comes to think that Maithili storytellers do not even understand what a children's story is.

The eighty-second Sagar Rāti will be devoted to children's stories. In that context, this workshop in storytelling and story writing for children is being initiated.

4

Jagadanand Jha "Manu" brought Chonhā to the Videha Children's Festival. Grounded in child psychology, this novel is almost a textbook for writers of children's fiction: it demonstrates how a story should be carried forward and brought to an end, and the originality of its plot distinguishes it. The Videha Children's Festival is available at the following link:

https: //sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-pothi/

5

Children's stories should be written so that they give pleasure both when read and when heard. They should resemble closet drama, which is not intended for staging but for reading alone or for reading aloud and listening in the company of a few others.

Simple ideas, a simple vocabulary and simple language are the keys to excellent writing for children.

The Rigveda's account of the great flood, Manu and the great fish; its descriptions of the Saraswati River and of wheeled chariots—all these anticipate the forms of early children's tales, as does the story of Gilgamesh in the Avesta. Even before the Rigveda there was an oral literature of gāthās and nārāśaṃsīs, and for that reason the Rigveda uses terms such as gāthāpati and gāthin.

Long before the Pañcatantra and its partial rewriting as the Hitopadeśa, the Jātaka stories told tales for children through birds, animals and other creatures, although one purpose of the Jātakas was the propagation of Buddhism. Similarly, while telling stories for children, the Pañcatantra introduced prejudices against women and Śūdras; hence the need to rewrite it was felt. Rigvedic narratives gave rise to dialogue, which the Purāṇic tales brought to an end. The latter therefore need to be rewritten in accordance with the present age.

6

What should the modern children's story be like?

It should contain the beneficial elements disseminated by modern science, together with environmental awareness. In other words, it should be oriented towards practice rather than mere intellectualism.

To combine entertainment with knowledge in children's stories, we need fiction informed by science and the social sciences. Children must understand their heritage; folktales, fairy tales and magical stories may therefore be told, but they must be written or rewritten so that they do not encourage superstition.

Part II

Applied Studies

Critical examinations of stories, poetry, novels, drama, folk ballads, history, philosophy, the pañjī genealogical system, children's literature, translation, and contemporary linguistic and cultural works.

41. Why Should Readers Read My Books?

Abstract

First of all, one may have heard that a work is good—but how is one to obtain the book? Earlier, sending books to Nepal cost about as much in postage as sending them within India. Now postage costs more than the book or magazine itself, and books are no longer sent to Nepal. If I am in New Jersey, and Maithili books and magazines are hardly available even in Madhubani and Darbhanga, where are they to be found in Uganda, the United States or Australia?

Keywords: readers · books · reading · poetry · literary reception

Why Should Readers Read My Books?

I would therefore tell you that all my writings are available on the Internet at http://www.videha.co.in/new_page_90.htm. This is a declaration that geographical boundaries have ended; there is no limit of stock to restrict availability either.

I shall now describe my books under the following divisions:

Original writings

Verse (poems, lyrical compositions and long poems, ghazals, and poems and ghazals for children)

Prose (stories, novels, criticism, essays, treatises, plays, editorials and children's literature)

Translations

Prose—my translations of general fiction and children's literature

Verse—my translations of poetry

Let us begin with verse. Uday Narayan Singh quoted some of my poems, which appealed to him. I reproduce his assessment below:

"Several lines may well become inscribed upon the reader's mind, such as:

> 'A wall of crumbling emotions,
> A pillar of frailty stands upright;
> The storehouse of desires is full.
> There it stands as a symbol—
> The temple of Himalayan wood kept in the house, or
> The tulsi plant placed on the veranda—
> Merely a symbol of fellow feeling.'

Or consider these lines:

'Listening to the spectacle of emptiness,
The canvas of nature,
The painting of a roaring sea,
The words of the figures in a painting of dark caverns:
No one will see this picture of mine in the dark,
Yet surely someone will hear the voice of the figure's longing.'

The influence of many cultures—not only of Mithila, but of India more widely—can be discerned in his stories and poems. This widens the field of active creative writing in Maithili, bringing forward fresh images, sounds and narratives.

What Mandākinī is the poet seeking when he says:

'The Mandākinī that was in the sky

I saw today upon the earth...'

His extensive travels clearly leave their mark upon his writing. Another distinction is plain: Gajendra Thakur the lexicographer and Gajendra Thakur the creative writer are different figures, even different personalities. In the former one encounters the editor and the technologically engaged individual; at the moment of creation, however, all of that disappears.

Many of the works contain not merely rounded narratives but political commentary as well, and he does not hesitate to offer it. Consider the many great warriors of Kurukshetra: each was accomplished and renowned within his own domain—one in commanding several akṣauhiṇīs of soldiers, another in archery, and so on. All knew the distinction between dharma and adharma, yet each seemed helpless before impending disaster. Similar circumstances appear in narrative and interpretation in our own time. This may be called the distinctive strength of the meta-text. Otherwise why would he write:

Watching the country's people being overtaken,
Awake at a noon filled with spells and incantations,
A dream steeped in murmuring thought
Becomes the fastest runner of all,
The fleetest wrestler in the arena;
The panting master's voice shatters its solitude,
Its sleep on a night painted black;
The succession of sleep and dreams breaks, returns, and breaks again,
...
It would be equally appropriate to read this meta-text as an experiment, as a distillation of the constellation of the Seven Sages, or as a modern epic divided into seven kāṇḍas."

Rajdev Mandal writes:

"Seated at the game board of the millennium, you are watching life's play. Through profound exploration you create image after image and become immersed in that exhilaration.

'A scene beside the boundless sea,
The heart filled with exhilaration...'

The poet within you summons an image of the sun and says:

'The sun's rays spread everywhere;
How many mysteries vanished;
The mist of darkness grew fearful—
But what is this...?'

I had the welcome opportunity of reading some haiku in the collection—something to vary the taste. Your poems bring the fragrance of Mithila into our minds:

'I remember the paddy fields,
The cicadas and the kachaurī,
The gleaned sheaves of harvested rice,
The red fireworks bought with the money
Earned from the grains gathered there,
Known as the red stick,
And the game of seven paths...'

Living away from home brings memories of the village and family. These lines express the pain of separation in a new rhythm:

'I do not know whether I shall return,
Or die and be worn away here,
And vanish...'

The satire is plainly visible in these lines:

'No delay in striking with the stick,
Nor much sorrow when it is only a heifer;
Yet you are the one who must be worshipped...'

The attempt to contain the problems caused by floods within brief lines—to hold an ocean in a pitcher—is evident here:

'Here and there the embankment had been cut;
Rain fell from above;
All the paddy and rice stored in the wall-side bins,
The fallen partitions, became the prey of water...'

The poems abound in fresh images:

'Like a thousand floods, monstrous,

The tangle of unfolding events;
My breath swelled and faltered;
I sprang up in alarm...'

You did not merely spring up in alarm; you awoke into awareness, with new images and sounds and a new vision. Who knows how far you will go, or where your destination lies?

'In the churning of the world,
Something new will now come forth...
We shall seek the path of the path itself...
The journey has now become long...'"

All these poems may be found in my book Sahasrābdīk Chaupaṛ Par (On the Game Board of the Millennium).

I now present two poems from my book Sahasrajit.

The Evil Eye Falls Upon Him

Mother says
That the evil eye falls upon him.
She looks at her son and thinks how handsome he is today;
By evening a shadow falls across his face.
Indeed! Whose son could be like mine?
Yet even as she thinks it, the evil eye may fall upon him.
He begins a task,
So many tasks all at once,
And remembers nothing else until they are done.
If someone says, "How wonderful your son is,"
Mother's heart suddenly misses a beat;
Her heart begins to sink.
What is he doing?
What beauty do they see in him?
And yet Mother goes on saying
That the evil eye falls upon him,
Upon my son at the slightest word.
The young wife tells her mother-in-law,
"Mother, your son is not one to be frightened;
No wicked eye can harm your son."
But on Saturdays Mother burns mustard seeds and chillies.
"If he starts sneezing, we shall know no evil eye has fallen on him;
And if he does not sneeze, the evil eye has caught him."
When he does not sneeze for a while, Mother grows anxious:
"Just see how the evil eye catches my son over the smallest thing...
The evil eye catches him... over every little thing..."

Just then the son sneezes: the smoke has reached his nose.
A smile comes over Mother's face.
She adds a little more mustard seed and chilli to the fire...
"Didn't I tell you, Mother, no wicked eye can harm your son?"

Kaṭihārī

I

There is a biting chill in the wind.
This cold will enter the very bones.
The body, after the post-mortem,
Lies upon seven thick slabs; soon it will burn.
The cow-dung cakes Sumanji brought for the fire
Have been placed underneath.
He plunges into the icy water,
Takes flame from the fire of the cow-dung cakes,
To give the body its final passage, its proper rites,
And consigns it to the fire,
With grass, wood and ghee.
Everyone will go back,
Crossing and touching iron, stone, fire and water,
Leaving behind the mother with a child of a month and a half in her arms;
All return to their homes.
It is dawn, after the final night of the first decade of the twenty-first century,
But there is no difference.
Set aside changes of clothing and male domination;
Look at the condition of women.
More savage than this freezing wind,
It enters the bones.
Not beside the Kamala, but beside the Yamuna,
A thousand miles from the village,
The white garments of Khararkhawālī Kākī blur together.
The very same story as sixty years ago,
The very same society;
Only the clothing has changed,
Only the river's course has changed.
That body upon the seven slabs—
The flames devour it, crackling and roaring.
A family must be made anew;
Thirty years later we shall see the outcome.
Until then this cold will remain embedded in the bones,

Colder by far than the chill of this wind.

2

Gopīchandan, gaṅgauṭ, a garland, fresh white garments;
A tulsi leaf, a piece of gold and Ganges water in the mouth;
Kuśa grass spread on the ground near the tulsi plant,
The head turned northward:
The body after the post-mortem.
Sumanji too puts on fresh white garments,
The sacred thread and an upper cloth; with water from a new earthen vessel,
Facing east, he recites mantras with the kuśa grass,
And sprinkles the deceased with that water.
Holding a torch in his left hand, he lights it from the cow-dung fire.
After circling the dead three times,
Fire is offered to the mouth:
Cotton, wood, ghee, incense, camphor and sandalwood.
The dead is clad in a dove-like white.
Each person places five pieces of wood.
When the body has become a lump of flesh like the burnt remains of a dove,
They take the seven ritual sticks, circle seven times,
And cut the torch into seven or six pieces with a kurharī,
Severing the seven bonds;
The seven satkaṭhiyā sticks are thrown into the fire.
With children and elders sent ahead,
They hurry away, shielding their heels,
To bathe;
An offering of sesame and water is made with the ritual vessel.
Without drying their bodies,
They return to the courtyard of the deceased.
At the threshold they touch, in order, iron, stone, fire and water,
Then go back into their homes.

Manikant Das wrote, “Tvam Chāham Cha” (“You and I”); I liked it very much.

My Ghazals

Om Prakash Jha writes:

“Although all those who compose children's ghazals are capable of doing so, and are producing excellent work, I think it appropriate in this connection to mention a children's ghazal by Gajendra Thakur. Its opening couplet is:

'Leave the bride-and-groom dolls; bring Barbie;
If she is pink, you may call her Barbie.'

Read the whole ghazal. By mentioning the traditional dolls, it certainly entertains children; at the same time, it offers a poignant reflection on people sacrificed upon the altar of contemporary market culture."

He writes of this composition:

A Children's Ghazal

Leave the bride-and-groom dolls; bring Barbie;
If she is pink, then recognise Barbie.
Those daityas who wander from forest to forest—
Imagine Barbie returned with the vanasaptā.
Morning arrives in the village bearing seven colours;
The fairy lives there—listen to the village, Barbie.
The children will be freed of their shivering;
Forget the tears that filled your eyes, Barbie.
Travel everywhere, through water, sky and earth;
Affix wings to your forehead ornament; listen, Barbie.
Play and leap about with the dhamma doll;
Bring dreams and sleep into the night, Barbie.
Put this doll to bed, and go to sleep yourself;
Mount Airāvata and sing of the day, Barbie.

Original Maithili text

कनियाँ पुतरा छोड़ू आनू बार्बी
जँ रंग गुलाबी छै तँ जानू बार्बी
बोने-बोने फिरैए जे दैता सभ
वनसप्तो लऽ घूरलि मानू बार्बी
सात रंग लऽ भोर भेले गाममे
परी रहैए गाम अकानू बार्बी
कननी दूर हेतै बच्चा सभमे
भरल आँखि बिसरी ठानू बार्बी
पानि अकास धरती जा-जा घूमी
पंख लगा टिकुली अकानू बार्बी
धम्म गुड़िया संग खेलू कूदू
राति सपनाउ निन्न आनू बार्बी
सुता दियौ ऐ गुड़ियाकेँ आ सुतू
चढ़ि ऐरावत दिन गानू बार्बी

This is included in my ghazal collection Dhāṅgi Bāṭ Banebāk Dām Agūbār Pene Chhaṅ, of roughly a hundred pages: the ghazals occupy forty pages and a study of Maithili ghazal poetics occupies sixty.

I reproduce the book's title ghazal here:

A wayfarer on love's bitter, difficult path since time immemorial,
Carried an aged, overwhelming love in both hands;
When pure fingers touch its back,
A fluttering pain spreads through the unfeeling throat;
That guileless love, innocent and unblemished,
Was a drawn bow meant to wound the lover;
It knew no difference between acts and duties,
Nor did it ever conceal the burning talk of love;
Airāvata is no battered creature of the road—you are upon the road;
I have received the payment in advance for making my own way.

Original Maithili text

अकत तीत प्रेमक जे पथिक अदौकालसँ
धतालबूढ़ प्रेमकेँ बोहेलक दुनू हाथजँ
निर्मल आंगुरसँ छूबै जे ओकर पुठपुरी
फरफैसी पसारै निदरदी अगिलकण्ठ जँ
निमरजना प्रेम जे छलै धपोधप निश्छल
बिदोरै लेल प्रेमीकेँ छलै ओ कड़ेकमान तँ
अकरतब कर्तव्यमे भेद नै बुझलकै जे
जराउ प्रेमक गप्प नै कहियो नुकेलकै जँ
खञ्जखूहर ऐरावत नै बाटक छेँ बाटमे
धांगि बाट बनेबाक दाम अगूबार पेने छेँ

In an interview Munna Ji asked me a question. The interview is available on page 415 of Videha: Sadeha, no. 33; I reproduce an excerpt:

Munna Ji: Despite all this work, there has still been no assessment of you—either of your personality or your writing. Does that affect you?

Gajendra Thakur: No, I do not agree with that. The emails and letters I have received, readers' letters of appreciation, the success of my plan for preserving manuscripts, and my research in linguistics have all given me satisfaction. How could bad people also speak well of you? Nor would I want them to. In Maithili, as in other languages, a full assessment of both personality and literary achievement takes place only after death.

'My mind has become as pure as the waters of the Ganges;
The Lord follows me, calling "Kabir, Kabir."'
(Kabir)

(The mind has grown as pure as Ganges water, and God follows behind, calling out Kabir's name.—Kabir)

Airāvata is no battered creature of the road—you are upon the road;
I have received payment in advance for making my own way.

(Others are paid after completing their work; I have been paid beforehand.)

Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’: “This observation by Gajendra Thakur is entirely correct: ‘The more a person can become a child, the better the children's ghazals that person will compose.’”

Chandan Kumar Jha: “Gajendra Ji not only strengthened the grammar of the ghazal through his writing; he also gave the world of the Maithili ghazal two invaluable metrical forms—the simple syllabic bahr and the simple quantitative bahr. These have helped many newcomers and learners like me to write ghazals, and have enriched the Maithili ghazal in an unprecedented way.”

Ashish Anchinhar writes:

“Recently, however, Gajendra Thakur successfully composed a ghazal in bahr-e-mutaqārib, and it therefore deserves discussion. The syllabic bahr used in Maithili was also identified by Gajendra Thakur, and almost every new ghazal writer now follows it.”

The ghazal is reproduced below.

Bahr-e-Mutaqārib

Bahr-e-mutaqārib: eight rukns; the foot faʿūlun (U ׀ ׀), repeated four times.

You take me for a gambler without cause;
What is the point of this strange way of living without cause?
I raised the outcry and sang away my sorrow;
Why do you make a spectacle of it, like a showman, without cause?
Whatever new covering is put in place wears away;
No one returns to set it right, without cause.
Fasting at home and hopeless outside,
In famine and distress, helpless without cause.
You go forward in hope, bearing the palanquin;
Yet the funeral pyre approaches—think of it, without cause.

Original Maithili text

अहाँ बूझि लै छी जुआरी अनेरे
जिबै कोन बैबे नियारी अनेरे
हहारो उठेलौं उदासी गबेलौं
सिहाबै किए छी मदारी अनेरे
जतेको नबारी छबारी बुरैए
घुरेबै कियो नै सुतारी अनेरे
घरोमे उपासे बहारो निरासे

दहारे अकाले नचारी अनेरे
चलै छी खटोली उठा ऐ भरोसे
भसाठी अबैए विचारी अनेरे

And here are a few couplets from the same collection. If, as you approach the end, any of them makes you pause, please be sure to let me know at the email address below.

A bird flies and the wind blows without purpose through this blue sky;
When the Airāvata of the mind takes flight, how shall I hold it?
What I have seen and known has arrived even today;
The protecting lamp is being extinguished.
What can I tell whom—and who will believe me?
Meaning is abundant in every depth.
I do not turn a deaf ear to you; why speak so?
Hate me, if that is what fills your heart.
A thick line of worry upon the forehead;
What was small has now grown enormous.
Amid the spreading fire of longing,
I said that greatness had become its distinguishing sign.
Today's conversation will come to an end;
The morning wind has become fierce.
Ask everyone; leave no one out.
Why was the new dawn held back?
The wind rose with a quiet sob;
The strength of the inner mind will truly change things.
My love is like a fish without water, turned upside down;
Having found love, what labour will they undertake?
The claim to sharpness became counterfeit knowledge;
Every moment the barking cuts through the laughter.
The performer, dressed for adversity, laughs;
You too have seen what I have seen.
I have bathed at the ghāṭ of fear;
And so I shall endure oppression from every direction.
Airāvata sees light, the wild flood, and famine;
I see this eclipsed sun exhausted and bewildered.
People talk much of the moon's radiance;
The kherhā of this slanting light said so.
I shall walk by the field boundaries and reach there;
It stands in the middle of the road; I cannot stop it.
And I saw a round fragment of cloud falling in the sky;
I looked eagerly towards the fields: joy climbed the mountain.
Go where you will; even the small bird fled in the moonlight;

The dark night, and life grown tangled and overgrown.
However much moonlight there may be, night remains everywhere;
Even by day there is an eclipse, and darkness spreads all around.
Cast away the thoughts of the mind in a sweep;
When things cleared, they became unmanageable.
A crocodile has come into our neighbourhood;
A burial in water has become a business.
Airāvata is not the elephant in the elephant–crocodile struggle;
A new understanding has arisen between the two.
My eyes are closing; tell me, what shall I do?
I cannot understand; anger is rising—what shall I do?
Here the rice crop has turned into empty husks,
And green fire is blazing—tell me, what shall I do?
A moment of seeing, touching and experiencing:
These lines will not become history.
With a house built beside the embankment, I wait for the road;
Do not lose your way and linger—what is that to me?
The flowing current of falsehood had stopped;
When it reversed its course, it burned again and again.
How many days have passed listening for the sting's approaching blow?
That same returning presence altered, passed by, and went away.
Even Lachchhan learnt his father's obstinacy;
Forgetting right and wrong, he became just like him.
I could not fathom the kherhā of the night-watch and the constellations;
I could not unravel the kherhā in the morning's lines.
The little bird has been ensnared like this;
They say this hunter is a great well-wisher.
After waking from sleep I saw a cruel dream and a beautiful life;
How could I believe anyone who says that nothing ever changes?
They say that today they will mix a little lump into the tears;
If he comes having drunk bhāṅg, the emotions too will become intoxicated.
What permanent colour can I paint with, one that will never fade?
Even the colours of the mind fade; come, let us return.
At daybreak the sadness flies away;
The drizzle that has scattered its drops is you.
How often have I fashioned this spinning expanse?
We await the way of escape and call ourselves the sun.
Seeing it, I understood the stages of formation;
As a figure takes shape, you become visible.
What has been left, not even one thing for the solitary person?

I wake in the dark and begin counting.
The beloved has gone far away to another land;
No one returns, and I no longer seek that hope.
Who will write down a new form of yourself when you utter it?
Who will send the broad north–south road flowing then?
The palms will always feel the biting cold;
If you were to hunger for it, how would you find its flavour?
If fortune weeps somewhere upon the flight from home,
When will Gajendra's heart understand and be consoled?
Whoever saw the banyan tree said, "This is Vrindavan itself";
With the courtyard in disarray, perhaps it is better now to leave it deserted.
The one no one asks about anywhere is invited to Saurath;
There is no love in the moon's course—perhaps it is better now to forget.
An elephant is heavy upon its own feet, as an ant is upon its own;
Airāvata, bound in the chains of love, ought not to stumble.
The habit of enduring suffering has taken hold;
The knot that forms begins to look beautiful.
Like a fish I grow restless, wondering when I shall be caught in the net;
If I am caught and find deliverance, who will see with those eager eyes?
I did not understand how the matter had grown so large;
Today I saw him drifting away.
How much he used to demand of me, again and again;
Now he leaves without taking what had accumulated.
His cry of anguish could hear my silence;
He is leaving without hearing me speak.

Now let us turn to some of my haiku, senryū, tanka and haibun.

Like the vihani tale, these literary forms are not generally regarded as serious. But if the compositions below, taken from my book Sahasrajit, strike you as serious, I shall consider my work successful.

I

Nature's Anger

With kuśa grass, sesame and water,
कुश तिल जलसँ

becoming a widow—
विधवा बनि
what distinguishes her from a married woman?
सधवा की विभेद
With dūb grass, unbroken rice and water. (Tanka / waka)
दूबि अक्षत जल (टनका / वाका)

From the oleander,
करबीरसँ
houses, trees and mountains
घर गाछ पहाड़
are encircled. (Haiku)
घेरल अछि (हाइकू)

The forest people:
बनैया लोक
the watercourse by the house
घरक पनिबह
does not depart. (Senryū)
बिदति नहि (शेनर्यू)

Pull up the wild roots and eat them; bring nature into your home, plant a flower garden, and hang a photograph of the mountains on the wall. Then you become a lover of nature. Carry the village into the city—through painting, artistry and ingenuity.

We are playing
खेलाइ हम
at kariyā-jhummari;
करियाझुम्मरिमे
beneath us, the sky.
नीचाँ अकास

Where can one find a single-track road now? Even a four-lane road is considered too narrow: six lanes, eight lanes. The sky is stained, the green of the trees is stained, the mind itself is stained. But the roads and houses are as sleek and polished as photographs. Let us write with pictures.

Today the outline of a house:
घरक खाका आइ
I am bewildered.
छी जङलाह
(Haibun)

2

1.

In search of nature,
तागि प्रकृति
I crossed over to look for it—
ताकैले भेलौं पार
a withered leaf.
सुखल पात
(Haiku)

2.

These flowers and fruits,
ई फूल फल
as one climbs farther on,
चढ़ैत जाइ आगाँ
grow fewer.
कम होइए
I turn and look again:
उनटि देखी फेर
less nearby, more at a distance.
लगमे कम दूरे बेशी
(Tanka / waka)

3.

They have shed their colour—
रंग छाड़ल
mountains and trees—
पहाड़ आर गाछ
but life remains.
मुदा जीवन
(Senryū)

4.

So many dazzling colours! Nature—the flowers, leaves, roads and sky—shines more brightly than a child's picture book. And beyond all these is the snow: a desert in its own right, with snow in place of sand, without oxygen, flowers or leaves. Yet look at its grandeur. The road along which I came did not shine so brightly. When I stood close to that landscape I could not fully apprehend its beauty. Someone looking from far away

might have admired me too; amidst nature, I myself would have become part of nature. But from this summit the landscape appears so beautiful.

It has become a tree,
गाछ भेल छै
a solitary child;
असगरुआ बौआ
it has become a leaf,
पात भेल छै
a plaything of nature.
खिलौना प्रकृतिक
Beholding the summit,
शिखर देखि

Yet now that I have reached this summit, I feel the journey was in vain. Seen from below, it looked so beautiful; now, from its height, that same village seems more beautiful. Only when I see the village landscape from the summit can I compare the two: summit from village, village from summit. But desire keeps calling me onward. Now I shall cross to the other side of the peak and look at the people and their society there. From a distance the villages on both sides appear equally lovely, lying below; but will the summit seem as beautiful from the village beyond as it did from the village on this side?

Do not stand still.
नै ठाढ़ होउ
Come, let us go back.
चलू चली घुरैले
I am a trader,
बनिजार छी
among the people,
लोकक बीचमे छी
coming and going.
जाइत घुरैत छी

(Haibun)

3

It lies scattered / this trailing mat of reeds / gather it and eat.
चतरल छै/ लतरल टाट ई/ झोरा कऽ खाउ

This lightning-like flash / spreads as a root's veins / spread outward.
ई बिजलौका/ जड़िक शिरा सन/ पसरैए

Bursting from the root / it crackles / across the horizons / spreading everywhere / until it covers all.
जड़िसँ फूटि /ई कड़कड़ाइत/ दिग दिगन्त/ पसरत सगरे/ करत आच्छादित

There is no reason / to surrender; and victory / calls for no pride.
कारण नै छै/ हारि लेल, विजय/ लेल नै गर्व

People of the netherworld / ships in the sky / the world turned upside down / worlds and the universe / all thoughts and arguments.
लोक पताली/ जहाज अकासमे / उनटि गेल / विश्व लोक ब्रह्माण्ड / बात विचार सभ

A world of water / upon the ocean floor / astonishing colours.
जल दुनियाँ/ समुद्र तलपर/ अद्भुत रंग

Without turmeric / Chanakya's poisonous / poison-maiden.
बिनु हरदि/ चाणक्यक बिखाहि / विषकन्या ओ

Without turmeric / she became venomous / the poison-maiden / who had been brought up / without turmeric.
बिनु हरदि/ बनलि बिखाहि ओ / विषकन्या जे/ पालित भेल छलि/ बिनु हरदिक जे

Turmeric has qualities upon qualities. When you catch cold, put clarified butter and turmeric in milk, close your eyes and drink it down. If you are injured, mix lime with turmeric and apply the paste. Without turmeric, neither dal nor khichri looks yellow: the khichri would look insipid and the dal strangely coloured. The plant looks somewhat like a vaijayantī flower, but it grows in a cultivated plot, not on the embankment of a pond as the vaijayantī does. Turmeric plant / concealing in its root / its virtues. (Haibun)

4

Hope has come: / the rainbow has risen / let us move ahead. (Haiku)
आसक अछि/ पनिसोखा उगल/ चलू बढ़ै छी (हाइकू)

Deliverance has come; / the rainbow has risen; / let us set to work; / step outside the house; / a road has appeared. (Tanka)
भेल उबेर/ उगल पनिसोखा/ काज करै छी/ बहराइ घरसँ/ बाट भेटल अछि (टनका)

This rainbow / has risen in the sky, / higher and higher! (Senryū)
पनिसोखा ई/ उगल अकासमे/ उपरे ऊपर! (शेनर्यू)

Ah, deliverance will come now: the rainbow has appeared, the path has opened. The labourer sets out to trade, the farmer lifts the seedlings for transplanting, and I too depart on some work that is no work at all—along an endless road, for work that might be worthwhile, towards a directionless, halted crossroads.

Waiting for the road,
बाट तकैत
we look up to the sky;
ताकी अकास दिस
a curious delusion,
विचित्र भ्रम
as though this rainbow
जेना ई पनिसोखा
would rise and open the way.
उगि खोलत बाट

Then I shall look again, seek my equal, and go on walking until the rain begins. But if I say that I shall keep walking until the rain, is that not a kind of flight? The rainbow has risen, the road has opened, and I am watching the road for the rain that is yet to come.

Seven-coloured
सतरंगिया
is this hope;
अछि ई आस
hope arises,
उगैए आस
the sky is about to sink—
डुबबाले अकास
it has become terror.
बनि गेल संत्रास

(Haibun consisting of two prose passages and two tanka)

Now, some kuṇḍaliyā, again from my book Sahasrajit.

Kuṇḍaliyā

I

Distinguish truth from falsehood; harbour no resentment.
सत असत मे भेद करू, राखू नै किछु रोख
Do not waver even a little before what destiny has written.
ततमत नै करू कनियो, जे छै होनी लेख
Whatever destiny has written—how might that turn out well?
जे छै होनी लेख, हुए से नीक निकेना
Truth will triumph if you do not persist in wrongdoing.
सत्यक जीत हएत, जँ करबै अकसतिकस ने

Let fear of falsehood fall; break the fear within the heart.
डर संग असत केर, डर ढाहू मध्य हृदयक
Airāvata understands: such is the truth of what is false.
ऐरावतक बुझैत, यएह छी असत्यक सत

2

The whirling swarm under the umbrella's fringe turned day to darkness.
छत्ता घुरछा पल्लौसँ, भेल दिने अन्हार।
Returning home at day's end, I found time had become terrible.
दिन बितलापर घर घुरी, काल भेल विकराल॥
Time had become terrible; every limb shuddered.
काल भेल विकराल, पोरे-पोर सिहरैए।
Who would hear a question? Words were being raised like an alarm.
सुनत केओ सवाल, बोल बगहा लगबैए।
Airāvata was distraught: where had the words disappeared?
ऐरावत बेहाल, बोल कतऽ भेल निपत्ता।
Whirling in like death itself, they entered the dense swarm beneath the canopy.
घुरियाए बनि काल, पैसि बिच घोरन छत्ता। ।

3

If victory comes without pride, know that this is good.
विजय बिन गर्व हएत जँ, बुझू तखन ई नीक
Do not panic in defeat; understand this, my friend.
हारि भेने घबराउ नै, बात बुझू ई मीत
Understand this, my friend, even if a quarrel arises.
बात बुझू ई मीत, हुअए जँ एक झमेला
Accept defeat and move forward; do not stir up another dispute.
हारि मानि बढ़ि जाउ, करू ने फेर बखेरा
Where work has brought contentment, that alone is good.
भेल काज प्रसन्न जतऽ, नीक अछि टा सएह
Understand, O Airāvata's mind, and behold defeat and victory.
मोन ऐरावत बुझि, देखि ली हारि-विजय

4

Let your words be good; speak after you have understood the matter.
बोल वचन हुअए नीक, बूझि बाजी जँ बात
Sometimes it is better to remain silent when a great snare lies ahead.
गुम्म रहनाइए ठीक, हुए जँ नमहर जाल

When a great snare lies ahead, it will swallow you in a single gulp.
हुए जँ नमहर जाल, लेत ओ लप दऽ भीतर
Speech will turn into an uproar if its moment is not right.
हल्ला बनि जाएत, नै अछि जँ बेर उचित पर
Listen to me: words are priceless.
सुनू हमर ई बात, बात होइए अनमोल
Airāvata says as he goes: do not speak words as hollow as the oal tuber.
ऐरावत कहि जाय, कहू नै ओल सन बोल

Now read the Flag Song of Mithila, from Sahasrābdīk Chaupaṛpar.

The Flag Song of Mithila

Mithila's flag shall fly throughout the world.
मिथिलाक ध्वज फहरायत जगतमे,
I have seen Mother angered, adorned and defiled;
माँ रूषलि, भूषलि, दूषलि, देखल हम,
I am restless, and my mind is in turmoil.
अकुलाइत छी, भँसियाइत अछि मन।
I come from the land of learning, industry and work;
छी विद्याक उद्योगक कर्मभूमि सँ,
your descendants will rise and return again,
पछाड़ि आयत सन्तति अहाँक पुनि,
with intelligence, resourcefulness and courage;
बुद्धि, चातुर्यक आ शौर्यक करसँ,
do not doubt their victory.
विजयक प्रति करू अहँ शंका जुनि।
Even if the Maithili language has grown faint of breath,
मैथिली छथि अल्पप्राण भेल जौ,
I shall make my entreaty in the language of conjunct sounds;
सन्ध्यक्षर बाजि करब हम न्योरा,
from the touch of my letters shall arise the explosion of speech;
वर्ण स्फोटक बनत स्पर्शसँ हमर,
your flag shall not fall, O Mother Mithila.
ध्वज खसत नहि हे मातु मिथिला।

(Using vocabulary from Vidyapati)

Now learn the calls of animals and birds through this children's song, from Bāṅk Baṅaurā.

The ox is threshing, isn't he?
बड़द करैए दाउन ने यौ
Elephant—agatt, pichhū, thāit, māil biri!
हाथी अगत्त, पिछू, थाइत, माइल बिरि
Hirr-hirr, piggy, come home with us.
हिर्र-हिर्र सुग्गर चलू संग घर घुरि
Tī-tī—the pigeon has flown above.
ती-ती परबा उड़ि गेल ऊपर
Lih-lih, goat, eat your grass!
लिह लिह बकरी घास तूँ खो
The ox is threshing, isn't he?
बड़द करैए दाउन ने यौ
Atū, the hen; kut-kut, the doggie.
अतू कुकुड़ कुत-कुत डॉगी
Kitty, pisū-pisū—will you come?
कैटी पिसू-पिसू आएत की?
Hearing chehai-chehai, the dove ran away;
चेहै-चेहै सुनि पारा दौगल,
we ran off the road and waited.
भागी छोड़ि बाट हम ताकी
Arr, goat, eat your grass!
अर्र बकरी घास तूँ खो
The ox is threshing, isn't he?
बड़द करैए दाउन ने यौ
Do not provoke him by calling ḍhehai-ḍhehai;
ढेहै-ढेहै कऽ नहि खौंझाबू
the bull will come into the threshing ground!
साँढ़ आओत खरिहानमे यौ
Come over here—re he, haure hau!
आव ठामे रे हे, हौरे हौ
The ox is threshing, isn't he?
बड़द करैए दाउन ने यौ

Now, the vihani tale

If the only things you have read under the name of the vihani tale are little humorous sketches, you may not take the genre seriously. Read a vihani tale from Galpa-Guccha. Read it more than once if necessary; I am confident that, as with haiku and haibun, you will begin to take this form seriously too.

Polygamy and a Hijra

"Poor woman, she has died," the villagers said when So-and-so Babu's third wife died.

"So-and-so Babu has cut his third wife's throat," said one man.

"You are quite right. When his first wife had no child, he married a second time. But when the second had no child either, he ought to have understood, shouldn't he?" said another.

"Yes, and instead he kept telling his third wife that God had denied him children because he did not care for his nephews. Imagine that!" said a third.

"That wretched hijra!" said the fourth, bringing the gathering to an end.

Yet this grand conference of four men was unanimous on one point: his first two marriages had been entirely proper.

My Novels

Shiv Kumar Jha "Tillu" writes in his essay "The Depiction of Dalit Characters in Maithili Novels":

"In Gajendra Thakur's Sahasrabāṛhani, an Indigenous person brings a medicinal root for asthma, and the fact that the root is no longer found in the forest a few years later indicates the depletion of the woods. His Sahasraśīrṣā, meanwhile, provides a detailed account of almost all the Dalit castes of Mithila. Although it contains only three houses, the washermen's settlement has become a separate hamlet. Clothes belonging to Marwaris from as far away as Jhanjharpur are cleaned here. The Mahiswar Brahmins who strut into wedding processions, shaking their belvatam and whistling, are not wearing their own clothes. They are wearing borrowed garments belonging to wealthy Marwaris. The Rajak washermen hire these clothes to them for two days. Budhan and Domi Safi are washermen. Domi Safi is now Domi Das, because he follows the Kabir Panth. There is another settlement, the leatherworkers' hamlet, home to Mukdev Ram and Kapildev Ram. Formerly it lay outside the village, beyond the bamboo grove. Now all the bamboo has been cut down and uprooted, and the expanding habitation has reached the leatherworkers' settlement. Homesteads and brick kilns continue to appear on every side. Their assistance is expected in everything from beating the drum to blowing the horn. When cattle die, the household remains ritually impure until they carry away the carcass. Bhola Paswan and Mukesh Paswan are Dusadhs, related to Gena Hazari through the latter's younger family branch. This is

the same Gena Hazari who saw a cow come to give milk upon a blade of kuśa at Kusheshwar Sthan and began excavating there. The image of Mahadeva kept sinking deeper; Mahadeva, established by Sita's son Kusha, was discovered by Gena Hazari."

"Mukesh Paswan's daughter Malti is a bank officer, and his son-in-law Mathuranand is principal of a DPS school. They live in a farmhouse near Vasant Kunj. Bhola Paswan and Mukesh Paswan continue to live in the village."

"During the famine of 1967, when every pond and depression had dried up except the Dakahi pond, the Prime Minister visited, and people showed how Musahars dug out edible roots there and ate them. Umesh, son of the leatherworker Mukdev Ram, has also set up his tools beside that open-air saloon, though he lives in Kishangarh. Besides mending sandals and shoes, he has learned to make duplicate keys. If you have a key, the copy costs fifteen rupees; if the key is lost, a replacement costs one hundred; if he must visit your home, the extra charge is two hundred. Raghuvir, son of Bichkun Sadai of the Musahar community, has learned to drive. He drives for a businessman in Vasant Kunj and lives in Kishangarh. Shrimant, son of Baudha Mallik of the Dom settlement, has a sector-maintenance contract. He employs two hundred people who collect household rubbish from the flats every morning and clean the roads and parking spaces early in the day. Some of them, particularly people from Nepal, also clean residents' windowpanes for two hundred rupees a month and work as newspaper hawkers. Bichkun Sadai, a Musahar, lives in Kishangarh, but in a house of his own."

Durganand Mandal writes:

"The affection of Shri Gajendra Thakur, editor of Videha, awakened creative energy within me. Many words that were not used in Maithili literature were dismissed as merely rustic. But when I read Thakur's Kurukshetram Antarmanak and came to know those words, my confidence grew stronger still."

Rajendra Kumar Pradhan writes:

"Shri Gajendra Thakur's novel Sahasrabāṛhani bears witness to numerous political and bureaucratic upheavals. His Sahasraśīrṣā is a remarkably successful attempt to disseminate political consciousness through the songs of Mohan, a Dalit singer, from Indian independence to the Right to Information. Running through it all are the politics of the village and of floods, extending from the village to Delhi."

In the novel-trilogy set in the fictional yet recognisably Mithila village of Garh Narikel, the novel following Sahasraśīrṣā is also being published serially online in Videha.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal writes: “The minute geographical descriptions of village life in Sahasrabāṛhani astonished me.”

Umesh Mandal writes:

“Every letter of Gajendra Thakur's Sahasrabāṛhani resonates with feeling. Its profoundly moving representation is rich in images of sensitivity and a coherent sense of economic life. It presents the agitated sorrow of Nand, a dutiful and honest man who fulfils his social responsibilities alongside the obligations of family life.”

Sahasrabāṛhani (novel)

Sahasraśīrṣā (novel)

Short Stories

Read “Sar-Samaj” and “Banvir” in Galpa-Guccha (a collection of vihani tales and short stories).

Read “Siddha Mahavir,” “Shabdashastram,” “Delhi,” and “Taskar” in Shabdashastram (a collection of short stories).

Yoganand Jha writes:

“Kurukshetram Antarmanak is a collection of Gajendra Thakur's writings in different literary genres. Its seventh volume brings together twenty-three children's stories. Most of them concern the folk heroes of Mithila, although about half a dozen may be called children's folktales, even though their language is wholly classical in character. This is an important example of ongoing work in the collection of folktales for children.”

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes:

“Gajendra Thakur is an extraordinary person, endowed with a keen intellect and tremendous energy. The reach of his talent is very wide. He has devoted himself wholeheartedly to the advancement of language, literature and society. He is multilingual; that quality is reflected in his dictionary-making, his translations between numerous languages, and his research of many kinds. He founded Videha, the first Maithili e-journal. Videha has given Maithili a global platform. For the preservation and development of Maithil culture, he has built an exceptional archive that continues to grow. Published in seven volumes, Kurukshetram Antarmanak is a garden of Gajendra Thakur's creative writing and critical

thought. No literary genre has escaped him. His many-coloured literary world is lucid and dedicated to the public good. In children's literature, the refinement and achievement of his art are unparalleled."

And now, Jagdish Prasad Mandal: A Biography (Videha: Sadeha 35, pp. 1105–1250).

o

The year 1947...

The tricolour flag of independent India was flying.

But the Communist Party held that India had not yet become independent.

True independence was still to come...

A village in Mithila...

A child was born there, in that very year...

In that independent—or not yet independent—India...

The father's death... poverty... lawsuits...

In the struggle for the dispossessed, he encountered the prison of an independent—or still unfree—India...

Today in Berma nobody possesses a holding larger than five or ten bighas...

In that village, the self-reliant culture of farming still survives...

There the exclusive dominance of Brahmanism over priestly practice came to an end...

And after the struggles had ended, his writing ushered a renaissance into Maithili literature...

Jagdish Prasad Mandal: A Biography... by Gajendra Thakur.

My Play

Ulkmukh

Ulkmukh (a play)

—The love between Gangesha and Vallabha is the theme of this play. But after the first two acts, the third and fourth change course: Udayana, Dina,

Bhadri, Acharya Vyaghra, Acharya Singh, Acharya Sarabh, the disciples Sahi, Khikhir, Narhiya and Bijji appear before us. The enactment of a conspiracy within history begins. Yet at the close of the fourth scene, Bhakta tells his disciple a secret... one that will return to memory even after it has been forgotten... becoming Ulkmukh...

—From the fifth scene onward there is reality in place of suggestion, truth in place of imagination...

—From the first through the fourth scene, cubical objects arranged in a chessboard pattern will stand on the stage; from the fifth onward, spheres signifying reality will take the place of those signs of past time and imagination.

—A great many commentaries exist on Gangesha's Tattvacintāmaṇi; Gangesha is called the author of Tattvacintāmaṇi. But his poem has become Ulkmukh!

Maithili drama...

is led into a new age of theatre...

Ulkmukh...

staged at the Videha Theatre Festival, 2012...

under the direction of Bechan Thakur...

with a stage conception in accordance with Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra...

Maithili Critical Theory, A Theory of Translation for Maithili, and Maithili Ghazal Theory

Atuleshwar writes: "A letter from Gajendra Thakur appeared in Hemani, asking whether it was not a conspiracy that, at gatherings such as Sagar Rati Deep Jaray—which has now become more a meeting for irrelevant talk than a forum for stories—people do not discuss what is weak in a story or what new elements it contains, but instead talk, in the Ramanathi manner, while going about eating and socialising."

Mayanand Mishra wrote: "I object to the criticism of my novel Stridhan in Kurukshetram Antarmanak..." Is it right to treat literary criticism as personal opposition?

Maithili Critical Theory

(For theory)

Maithili Critical Theory (Videha: Sadeha 35, pp. 1322–1416)

(For application)

An Examination of Booch Ji's Poetry from Marxist, Historical, Structuralist, Magical-Realist, Postmodern, Feminist and Deconstructionist Perspectives, alongside a Study from the Perspective of Indian Aesthetics

Videha: Sadeha 33, pp. 201–206)

A Theory of Translation for Maithili

A Theory of Translation for Maithili (Videha: Sadeha 30, pp. 131–135)

Maithili Ghazal Theory

Maithili Ghazal Theory (Videha: Sadeha 35, pp. 1251–1321)

Vidyapati's Bidesiya

Videha: Sadeha 33, pp. 192–198

For Candidates Preparing for Competitive Examinations

NTA-UGC / UPSC / BPSC: Maithili Optional — Gajendra Thakur

[The Place of Maithili in the Indo-European Language Family / The Origin and Development of Maithili: Sanskrit, Prakrit, Avahaṭṭa and Maithili]

(Criticism: Various Literary Genres of the Modern Period / Testing Candidates' Critical Ability)

(Criticism of Different Literary Genres of the Modern Period / Assessment of Candidates' Critical Ability)

(Badrinath Jha's Vocabulary and the Agricultural and Fisheries Vocabulary of Mithila)

(Value Addition — Paper I: Society and Culture in the Lorik Ballad)

(Value Addition — Paper II: Vidyapati)

(Value Addition — Paper II: Samples of Poetry Criticism)

(Value Addition — Paper I: Folk Ballads, Dance, Drama and Music)

(Value Addition — Paper II: Yatri)

(Value Addition — Paper II: The Maithili Ramayana)

(Value Addition — Paper II: The Maithili Novel)

(Value Addition — Paper I: Reflections on Words)

(The Origin and Development of the Tirhuta Script)

Appendices 1–2–3; Appendices 4–5

(The Relationship between Maithili and Other Eastern Languages: Bengali, Assamese and Odia [UPSC Syllabus, Paper I, Section A, Item 5])

[Maithili and Hindi / Bengali / Bhojpuri / Magahi / Santali — for the Maithili Optional Subject in the Bihar Public Service Commission (BPSC) Civil Services Examination]

NTA_UGC_NET_MAITHILI_01 — Gajendra Thakur

NTA_UGC_NET_MAITHILI_02 — Gajendra Thakur

TEST SERIES-1 — Gajendra Thakur

TEST SERIES-2 — Gajendra Thakur

GS (Preliminary)

TOPIC 1 — Gajendra Thakur

My Translated Literature

My emphasis has been chiefly on translating from other languages into Maithili, although I have also translated from Maithili into English. I have had two purposes. First, such translation enriches Maithili. Second, if we do not read the literature of our own and other languages, why should anyone else read ours? The first link below is for general readers; it contains a story and some poems translated into Maithili. The second link is to thirty-five illustrated books for children, deliberately produced in bilingual editions (Maithili–English).

1

Translated Literature (from Other Languages) — Gajendra Thakur

Videha: Sadeha 27 (Prose and poetry translated from other languages by Gajendra Thakur and Ravi Bhushan Pathak, from issues 1–350)

2

Children's Literature (Translation; Bilingual Maithili–English) — Gajendra Thakur

Titles in Translation: Children's Literature (Original Bibliographic Titles)

Original titles and documentary spellings are retained as bibliographic and archival data.

टोस्ट	बड़ीटा! कनियेटा!	एतऽ हम सभ रहै छी	भारतोल्लक राजकुमारी	भारतोल्लक राजकुमारी (बिनु शब्दक)
वुयो	कच-कच कचाक	चुन्नू-मुन्नूक नहेनाइ	नेना जे बैलूनसँ डेराइत छल	अद्भुत फिबोनाची अंक-शृंखला
हारू	अखन नै, अखन नै!	जन्मदिनक उत्सव भोज	मोट राजा पातर-दुब्बड़ कुकुड़	बचिया जे अपन हँसी नै रोकि सकैत छलि
अंग्रेजी	हम सूंघि सकै छी	छोट लाल-टुहटुह डोरी	करू नीक, भोगू नीक	ई सभटा बिलाड़िक दोख अछि!
चोभा आम!	हमर टोलक बाट	जखन इकड़ू स्कूल गेल	माछी फेर आउ टाटा!	अमाचीक जुलुम मशीन सभ
टिंग टोंग	पाउ-म्याऊ-वाह	कुकुड़क एकटा दिन	हमरा नीक लगैए	रीताक नव-स्कूलमे पहिल दिन

टोस्ट	बड़ीटा! कनियेटा!	एतऽ हम सभ रहै छी	भारतोल्लक राजकुमारी	भारतोल्लक राजकुमारी (बिनु शब्दक)
कनी हँसियौ ने!	लाल बरसाती	भूत-प्रेतक नाट्यशाला	आउ पएर गानी	कतऽ अछि ई अंक ५?

Munnaji: “For how long will you maintain your firm resolve to remain at the same wicket, despite abuse and insults, in order to prevent Maithili journalism from drifting away from its purpose—or in pursuit of truth?”

Gajendra Thakur: “In the dedication of Kurukshetram Antarmanak I wrote:”

> I had watched my father hold to truth in steadfast equanimity;
> पिताक सत्यकेँ लिबैत देखने रही स्थितप्रज्ञतामे
> only then did I understand that
> तहिये बुझने रही जे
> there would be no renunciation;
> त्याग नहि कएल होएत
> this is the path of one who refuses to yield.
> रस्ता ई अछि जे जिदियाहवला।

Many people in my village wept when they read these lines. They understand their meaning. But all I can tell you is that the future will decide.

42. Weight Management: A Personal Experiment and Experience

Abstract

This story begins in 2000, in the latter part of that year, when I weighed not 100 kilograms but 78–80 kilograms. I was then on leave for more than a year after a road accident in suspicious circumstances. Returning from government duty, before the beginning of the new millennium, I fractured my thighbone in two places. On the night of the accident, after my blood pressure fell to 60/40, the doctor declared an oxygen emergency at two in the morning.

Keywords: management · personal · experiment · experience · also · kilogram · I was

Weight Management: A Personal Experiment and Experience

This story begins in 2000, in the latter part of that year, when I weighed not 100 kilograms but 78–80 kilograms. I was then on leave for more than a year after a road accident in suspicious circumstances. Returning from government duty, before the beginning of the new millennium, I fractured my thighbone in two places. On the night of the accident, after my blood pressure fell to 60/40, the doctor declared an oxygen emergency at two in the morning. Other frightening complications followed, including a diagnosis of ARDS and fifteen days on a ventilator. There were three operations within a year; another year and a half passed before I could progress from crutches to a walking stick. Then came 15 August, which was also Raksha Bandhan that year, and on that day I began driving again.

During that period, my weight rose from 80 to 100 kilograms: I ate fish and rice, slept, and undertook almost no physical labour. That excess weight stayed with me for the next eighteen years. I should add that I now weigh 80 kilograms again. There is a story behind the loss. I was transferred for six months to another department for some essential work. All my colleagues and subordinates there belonged to a paramilitary force. I could not even run a hundred metres, while they urged me to run so that I might lose weight. One day, when my turn came, I told them that within three months I would bring my weight down to 80 kilograms again. I had a solid basis for making that promise.

Over the preceding eighteen years I had tried all sorts of methods, including giving up breakfast and living during the day on cucumbers alone, yet I had almost entirely failed to lose weight. So where did this sudden confidence about losing it in three months come from? What was the secret? I now had an example before me. My son is six feet three inches tall and, according to the age–height–weight requirements of the NDA,

had to reduce his weight from 100 to 67 kilograms. You will have understood that he too weighed 100 kilograms. I was convinced he would fail. He did fail to reach 67 kilograms, but he brought his weight down to 71 kilograms. That was a tremendous shock for me. I learned some of his secrets, and within three months my weight was 80 kilograms. Here I am sharing those very secrets.

The Secret Revealed

For three months I went through the entire day on water and black coffee alone, without milk or sugar. In the evening, following a modified keto diet, I ate only during a one-hour window, between eight and nine at night, and took no carbohydrates, rice, or chikkas-sohāri flatbread. I had decided that I would eat fats—chicken, fish, and paneer—and, among fruits, only watermelon. After a month I weighed 86 kilograms.

The Next Shock

Be prepared for another shock. The road was not so easy. My weight loss stopped, and that plateau lasted a whole month. Yet my target had been three months. It is relatively easy for the body to shed water and the like; that is why the journey down to 86 kilograms is relatively easy. After that, the stubborn elements of the body must be reduced, and only then does the difficult road begin. Two months after starting the modified keto diet, my weight began to fall again. I should also say that throughout this period I ran for an hour before the evening meal. The distance increased from 100 metres to two kilometres. My park is rather like a hill, so by the measure of your park it would amount to three kilometres. I live on the second floor. Previously, if I left something in the car on a Friday, I would wait until Monday to collect it, because climbing to the second floor left me breathless. Now I go up and down four times a day.

The Scientific Basis

During this period I also heard of deaths associated with keto. Those with comorbidities must therefore consult a doctor.

In this connection I wish to share two pieces of advice I have heard from eminent doctors. The first was from Dr Sarin, director of ILBS. I heard him say on television that after the age of fifty one should eat only one meal a day to keep the liver healthy. He also said that he had no stake in the coffee industry, but that drinking black coffee without milk or sugar, however often, was good for the liver. He even recommended eating ghee (!), saying that it benefits the good bacteria residing in the liver.

I also heard a doctor on All India Radio FM, whose name I cannot remember, speak about keto. He said that when carbohydrates are not

eaten during a keto diet, the body draws energy from its fat, and that fatty-liver problems consequently disappear. He advised patients with comorbidities to undertake the diet only with medical guidance and said that keto dieting should not continue for more than three months.

Nowadays

Even now I drink black coffee without milk or sugar several times a day. Apart from water I neither eat nor drink anything during the day. I play badminton for an hour daily and even defeat boys twenty years younger than I am. At night I eat rice with ghee, roti, fish, and other foods.

Once a week I also have a cheat day, when I drink tea or coffee with milk and sugar and eat such things as pizza. As I said earlier, I reached 80 kilograms two years ago, and that weight remains unchanged today.

43. Annie Ernaux and the Fictional World of Kapileshwar Raut

Abstract

The Swedish Academy has announced this year's Nobel Prize in Literature for eighty-two-year-old Annie Ernaux. Before that, in a tweet, the Academy recalled Rabindranath Tagore. "A butterfly counts not months but moments, and has time enough." Ernaux initially wrote autobiographical novels but soon came to write memoirs, and memoirs alone.

Keywords: Ernaux · Kapileshwar · Raut · fictional world · goes · self · discussion

1

The Swedish Academy has announced this year's Nobel Prize in Literature for eighty-two-year-old Annie Ernaux. Before that, in a tweet, the Academy recalled Rabindranath Tagore.

"A butterfly counts not months but moments, and has time enough."

Annie Ernaux began by writing autobiographical novels, but soon turned exclusively to memoirs.

This year, too, after a long interval, a Nobel Prize in science was awarded once again for research that imitates nature.

2

Gajendra Thakur on Five Stories by Kapileshwar Raut

Five Stories — Kapileshwar Raut

Snakebite; a local game that takes the life of a young boy; old agricultural practices and the need for innovation; feasts for holy men; the language of birds and animals; the little and the great traditions; caste, class, and power; a woman's perspective; the rich and the poor—all are present, but there is no trace of despair. There is fearless discussion of epic narratives and religious sects. The language and vocabulary used to express all this are exceptionally precise, and difficult to translate, because this world finds its full expression in Maithili.

The bite of a snake; a local game in which a boy loses his life; traditional agricultural practices and the need for innovation; feasts for ascetics; the language of animals and birds; little and great traditions; caste, class, and power; feminist inquiry; rich and poor—and nowhere a sign of despair. There is fearless engagement with epic stories and religious communities, expressed through a command of language and a precision of vocabulary

that make translation difficult, for only in Maithili can all these things be written with such natural ease...

Welcome to the mysterious world of parallel Maithili literature. We are reading five stories by Kapileshwar Raut, all five selected by the author himself as his finest.

Welcome to the mysterious world of parallel Maithili literature. Here you are reading five stories by Kapileshwar Raut which the author himself considers his best.

"Kumari Bhojan" begins in a festive atmosphere. During the ten days of Durga Puja, people collect a special kind of smooth clay from which they make earthen images of Mahadeva and clay lamps. Siyawati's husband died of snakebite, leaving her a widow. After three daughters she had a son, much younger than his sisters. The expense of marrying off her daughters drove her into debt. From this account of a life, the story opens a discussion of the actual significance of folktales and mythic narrative: it also asks how a collective effort made the killing of Mahishasura possible.

"Kumari Bhojan" opens amid festivities. Over the ten days of Durga Puja, people bring a particular kind of smooth clay to fashion earthen Mahadevas and lamps. Siyawati's husband died after being bitten by a snake, and she was widowed. Her son was born after three daughters and was therefore much younger than his sisters. The heavy costs of the daughters' marriages plunged her into debt. After these particulars, the discussion turns towards what the narrative tradition truly signifies, examining how collective action culminated in the slaying of Mahishasura.

In "Tharthari," another kind of discussion begins between a landlord and those who till his fields on a bitterly cold winter night. The scene is an open field, where the landlord has come to see how the cultivation is proceeding.

In "Tharthari," on a shivering winter night, a discussion unfolds between the landlord and the cultivators. The scene is an open field to which the landlord has come to inspect the agricultural work.

"Barka Khira" explores in depth the relationship between traditional and modern agricultural knowledge. A boy who once wandered about crying "ihait, ihait" to summon a male animal for the breeding of cows or buffaloes later becomes an agricultural scientist.

"Barka Khira" opens up the profound relationship between inherited and modern knowledge in farming. The boy who used to go about calling "ihait, ihait"—a cry to summon a male animal to breed with a cow or buffalo—grows up to become an agricultural scientist.

"Punarnava" may bring to mind the Tamil Nadu sport of Jallikattu. At the Jur Shital festival, a man dies during a contest pitting human beings against one another, and Basuni becomes a widow. When the women begin making their own decisions, the story raises questions of women's rights and autonomy.

Reading "Punarnava" may remind one of Jallikattu in Tamil Nadu. At the Jur Shital festival, a man is killed in a contest between people, leaving Basuni widowed. As the women begin to decide for themselves, many questions open up for the reader seeking a theory of feminist discourse.

Finally, "Bhumhur Aag" again offers the flavour of local culture. Caste hierarchy is unmistakable. Chetan Das belongs to the Musahar community; after coming into contact with an ascetic of the Keot caste, he becomes an ascetic himself. He goes to invite Ajab Das, an accomplished singer of devotional songs, to a grand feast of ascetics, but Ajab Das imposes conditions. Vivek Kumar says that all this is a consequence of social hierarchy; when dealing with people considered lower than themselves, he or Chetan Das might perhaps have imposed similar conditions.

Finally, "Bhumahur Aag" offers a particularly dense taste of local culture. The layers of caste hierarchy are clearly visible. Chetan Das is from the Musahar community. He meets an ascetic of the Kevat caste and becomes an ascetic himself. He goes to invite Ajab Das, skilled in singing bhajans, to a great feast of holy men, but Ajab Das sets certain conditions. Vivek Kumar considers these expressions of social stratification: when confronted with people ranked below themselves, Chetan Das—or he himself—might well have imposed similar conditions.

44. The Sharadindu Chaudhary Special Issue and Parallel Literary Discourse

Abstract

This issue is devoted to Sharadindu Chaudhary. Readers have remarked on social media that Videha's special issues on living writers and artists have become more important than the honours and awards of the Sahitya Akademi, Lalit Kala Akademi, and Sangeet Natak Akademi. Gajendra Thakur's observations on five stories by Ram Vilas Sahu.

Keywords: Sharadindu · Chaudhary · special issue · parallel · discourse · English · translation

Abstract

This issue is devoted to Sharadindu Chaudhary. On social media, readers have expressed the view that Videha's special issues on living writers and artists have become more important than honours and awards conferred by the Sahitya Akademi, Lalit Kala Akademi, and Sangeet Natak Akademi. My thanks to all contributors and readers.

Editorial for the New Issue

1

2

Gajendra Thakur on Five Stories by Ram Vilas Sahu

Parallel Literature and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

Parallel Literature and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

1

The Book of Bihari Literature (edited by Abhay K.)

This book contains five translations from Maithili into English by Vidyanand Jha. Nagarjun—Yatri in Maithili—and Usha Kiran Khan are placed in the Hindi section, although both have received Sahitya Akademi awards in the Maithili category. Vibha Rani and Rajkamal Chaudhary appear in the Maithili section, although both have also written in Hindi.

The book contains five Maithili-to-English translations by Vidyanand Jha. Nagarjun (Yatri in Maithili) and Usha Kiran Khan are assigned to the Hindi category, even though both received Sahitya Akademi awards in the Maithili category. Vibha Rani and Rajkamal Chaudhary are assigned to the Maithili category, though both also wrote in Hindi.

The book was edited by Abhay K., whose study of Sanskrit extended to school level. Nevertheless, he claims to have translated the Arthaśāstra directly from Sanskrit into English. On the basis of his Sanskrit training, the reviewer assesses the translation's strengths and weaknesses and suspects that an intermediate language may have been used. If that is so, acknowledging the intermediary source is a necessary principle of translation ethics.

The book has been edited by Abhay K., who studied Sanskrit up to high school. Yet he claims to have translated the Arthaśāstra directly from its Sanskrit original into English. I am proficient in Sanskrit; judging by the quality of the translation, I suspect an intermediate language was used between the Sanskrit text and its English rendering. Acknowledging the source is an ethical obligation.

In the reviewer's judgment, Vidyanand Jha's translations fall below the required standard. One example concerns the difficulty of finding an appropriate English equivalent for "olak sannā," and many other such cases are cited. The reviewer offers suggestions: begin with Rajnath Mishra's A Bird's Eye View on Mithila, which explains many local terms in English; then consult Umesh Mandal's illustrated dictionary in the Videha archive (www.videha.co.in), which also provides photographs of Mithila's plants, animals, and occupations. Videha's A Parallel History of Maithili Literature supplies examples of Maithili stories translated into English. What the translator presents as "exotic," the reviewer argues, is an organic element of Maithili itself, even if the representation of Maithili literature twenty years ago was different. The selection recalls Contemporary Maithili Short Stories, edited by Murari Madhusudan Thakur (Sahitya Akademi, 2005); the reviewer suspects that the same tendency, even the residue of an older selection, shaped it. Invoking Rip Van Winkle, he argues that the translator has failed to register the transformation of Maithili literature over two decades.

Vidyanand Jha's translations are below the expected standard. For example, he seems not to know how "olak sannā" might be rendered in English; there are many such instances. I have some suggestions for him. First read Rajnath Mishra's A Bird's Eye View on Mithila; it includes explanations of many of the terms for which he could not find English equivalents. Next consult Umesh Mandal's illustrated dictionary in the Videha archive (www.videha.co.in), which includes actual pictures of Mithila's plants, animals, and groups of skills. In A Parallel History of Maithili Literature (Videha, www.videha.co.in) one can also find sample English translations of Maithili stories. Thus the material that Vidyanand Jha presents as foreign or marvellous is in fact part of the elementary substance of life in the Maithili language—although two decades ago this might not have

been evident in representative presentations of Maithili literature. His choice of stories reminds me of Contemporary Maithili Short Stories, an English translation collection edited by Murari Madhusudan Thakur (Sahitya Akademi, 2005). The stories seem like leftovers from that kind of selection. Rip Van Winkle awoke after two decades, but Vidyanand Jha is still asleep and has not seen the changes that have taken place during those years.

If these translations are compared with the accomplished English translations of Latin American literature originally written in Spanish, the differences in quality and approach to translation become unmistakable.

Compare the translations in this selection with English translations of Latin American literature in Spanish, and the difference becomes obvious.

In the original reviewer's view, such selections are generally not governed by standards of literary excellence. He places this kind of HarperCollins publication among quickly assembled selections for hotel or airport readers. The book was announced on 22 March 2022; he therefore comments that a short interval of six or seven months made reliance on older material more likely than a genuinely new selection.

But such selections are not known for literary excellence. HarperCollins publishes selections of this kind for readers in five-star hotels and airport waiting rooms. The publisher announced the book on 22 March 2022, so within six or seven months one was more likely to receive old material than new.

2

The Bride: Lalit Kumar's English translation of Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Maithili classic Kanyadan. The translator is an assistant professor in the Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi.

The Bride: The Maithili Classic Kanyadan—an English translation of Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Maithili classic Kanyadan by Lalit Kumar, Assistant Professor, Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi.

I have pre-ordered the book. I will review it after it arrives in my Kindle account on 1 December 2022.

I have already ordered the book. After it reaches my Kindle account on 1 December 2022, I will comment on it.

3

Bharti's Cat: Yogendra Pathak Viyogi's English translation of Brajkishore Verma "Manipadma"'s original Maithili novel Bhartik Bilari; available on Amazon Kindle.

Bharti's Cat—Yogendra Pathak Viyogi's English translation of Brajkishore Verma "Manipadma"'s original Maithili novel Bharatka Bilari (available on Amazon Kindle).

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi has done noteworthy work. The translation appears to carry the spirit of the original language with it.

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi has done excellent work. The original language's spirit appears secure in the translation.

Folktales of Mithila and Gonu Jha of Mithila: Tales of Wit and Humour are both works by Yogendra Pathak Viyogi, available on Amazon Kindle.

Folktales of Mithila and Gonu Jha of Mithila: Tales of Wit and Humour—both books by Yogendra Pathak Viyogi, both available on Amazon Kindle.

4

Ram Vilas Sahu's Short Stories

Now enter the engaging world of parallel literature.

In "Kamatiya Haveli," the storyteller interprets oral history. The havelis were really outposts or centres. In Mithila, landlords who received rights under Cornwallis's Permanent Settlement were, in some places, styled Maharajadhiraj and the like. A whole chain of revenue collection stretched across Mithila, and outposts were established in different places for supervising agriculture and collecting rent. Madina Didi explains the significance of this history to Janki. Alongside it, the finer details of village life are depicted in a language that may seem unfamiliar to someone who has not read Maithili literature for twenty years.

In "Kamatiya Haveli," the storyteller interprets oral history. The havelis were in reality only outposts or centres. In Mithila, the landlords who received the Permanent Settlement under Cornwallis were called "Maharajadhiraj" and other such titles. In fact, the chain of rent collectors spread across the whole of Mithila; they established centres to oversee cultivation and collect revenue. Madina Didi explains this to Janki. Amid all these episodes, the subtle colours of village life emerge in a language that may seem strange or unfamiliar to someone who has not read Maithili literature for two decades.

The second story, "Dudhbechani," recounts Rita's sacrifice: she donates all her land and property to establish a school and a cowshed.

The second story, "Dudhbechani," is the story of Rita's sacrifice: she gives away her entire land and property to build a school and a cowshed.

"The Joy of Heaven" recounts in fine detail the story of Bauku Sada's family, displaced by flooding. The family belongs to the Musahar community; the original commentary also criticises insulting stereotypes directed against such communities.

"The Joy of Heaven" tells in fine detail the story of Bauku Sada's family, driven from their home by floods. They belong to the Musahar community, whom some writers—once part-time agricultural labourers themselves—have derisively described as "rat-eaters."

"Ghusa Ghar" refers to corruption in the Indira Awas housing scheme.

"Ghoos Ghar" refers to the corruption prevailing in the Indira Awas housing scheme.

"Shikshak Mahat" weaves together a village devastated by flooding, the migration that follows, the importance of education, and the narrow mentality of the elite.

"Shikshak Mahat" binds into a single narrative thread a village ruined by floods, the consequent migration, the importance of education, and the narrow-mindedness of the elite.

3

True Stories and Sayings from Village to Village

Under this heading is a true story from Rudrapur village in Madhubani district, one that still lives on the lips of its inhabitants.

(Source and narrator: Shri Shrimohan Chaudhary, village of Rudrapur.)

"Manganiya's Mother's Oil" (Karu Oil)—a proverbial saying current among people of every caste in Rudrapur.

Manganiya was of the Guar caste. The incident took place in Rudrapur, Madhubani, eighty or ninety years ago, when a bhari (ten grams) of gold cost fifty rupees. Manganiya was still a child, extremely hardworking and frugal. By the time he grew up he had bought ten bighas of land through his own labour. He rose at three or four in the morning and finished all his work; when he set off to work as a ploughman, people would ask him where he was going. He would answer, "Master, I'm going there to rest for three or four hours." He called ploughing "resting"—after all, what great rush was there in ploughing?

Ghatak Thakur, father of Julum Thakur, was a shopkeeper, a Brahmin by caste.

Early one morning Manganiya's mother went to Ghatak Thakur's shop and began to complain.

"Hey, how much oil did you give me for two paisa? I offered a little of it to Jitwahan, rubbed some on the child's (Manganiya's) feet, and fried some tarua for a guest. And in the night the cap of the bottle was left open, so the Bongmarna hen drank it up, making that bhubhūā-bhubhūā sound. How much oil did you give me for two paisa that all these things could be done with it in a single day?"

A Proverb

"The one with the greatest goitre is the great elder sister."

45. The Premlata Mishra "Prem" Special Issue and Parallel Literary Discourse

Abstract

This issue is devoted to Premlata Mishra "Prem." The editorial on the subject became rather lengthy, so it is presented separately. On social media, readers have expressed the view that Videha's special issues have become more important than the honours and awards of the Sahitya Akademi, Lalit Kala Akademi, and Sangeet Natak Akademi.

Keywords: Premlata · Mishra · Prem · special issue · parallel · discourse · literature

Editorial

1

This issue is devoted to Premlata Mishra "Prem." The editorial on the subject became rather lengthy, so it is presented separately. On social media, readers have expressed the view that Videha's special issues have become more important than the honours and awards conferred by the Sahitya Akademi, Lalit Kala Akademi, and Sangeet Natak Akademi. My thanks to all the contributors and readers.

2

Gajendra Thakur on Five Stories by Umesh Mandal

Parallel Literature

A reference to parallel literature is found in the Vedas, where "Naraśaṃsī" is mentioned as a form of parallel literature.

The Vedas, too, offer an indication of parallel literature, mentioning "Naraśaṃsī" as a form of it.

The need for parallel literature in Maithili arose because public and private academies were continually intervening in literature and literary dignity. These included the Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy in Delhi, the Maithili Academy in Patna, the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi, and the Nepal Academy —all government institutions. Beyond these academies, the so-called literary organisations enjoying Sahitya Akademi recognition became important vehicles for asserting control over the entire public space of Maithili literature. Financial support to these bodies and other narrowly based organisations produced a form of representation in Maithili's name that was mediocre and did not represent the broader literary society.

The need for parallel literature in Maithili became acute when official and private academies repeatedly attacked literature and identity: the Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy in Delhi, the Maithili Academy in Patna, the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi, and the Nepal Academy are all government institutions. In addition to these academies, the so-called literary associations accredited by the Sahitya Akademi continued to exert pressure on Maithili literature and its dignity. This was a chief means of keeping the language's literary field under their control. The financial support received by these bodies and other narrow organisations sustained an image of representation in Maithili's name that was average, restricted, and out of keeping with the real diversity of society.

The Videha Maithili Literary Movement and a Parallel History of Maithili Literature

Consequently, an effort began to document those segments of society, experiences, and voices that had been absent, neglected, or left without representation. Writing rich in vocabulary and direct experience became a transformative intervention in the literature and art of Maithili-speaking society. An insistence on excellence displaced mediocrity, and speakers of Maithili experienced their mother tongue's actual possibilities in a new way. The attempt to write a parallel history of Maithili literature arose against this background: so-called mainstream literature of middling quality, sustained by public or private grants and possessing only a limited readership and reception, continued to be presented by academies as representative literature. Literary magazines such as Muse India (www.museindia.com) were also used to reinforce that representation, while official radio and television stations continued to project this restricted image of Maithili literature.

Umesh Mandal is a storyteller of the parallel tradition. His language is rich in vocabulary, a quality essential for expressing the intended thought and subject matter accurately.

Umesh Mandal belongs to the parallel literary tradition. His language is rich in words, an essential quality for presenting the intended idea and narrative effectively.

He himself considers five of his stories his finest; all five are mentioned below, and the original texts are also presented alongside them.

2. "A Sikki-Mauni Basket Before a Child's Understanding" (for those who see culture solely in the craft of the sikki-mauni).

2. "A Sikki-Mauni Basket Before a Child's Understanding" (those who confine their understanding of culture to the craft of the sikki-mauni alone).

3. "Gruel and Rice in Life, Milk and Rice in Death...!" (humiliation while living, glorification after death).

5. "All Fourteen Guardians" (the fourteen protectors).

"At the Level of Work" (an assessment based on actual work).

The central character tries to write a new story for an occasional, all-night storytelling gathering of Maithili writers. In the process, he makes a plan, then changes its timing and shape. Through the exercise, his experiences and encounters re-emerge within the story.

The central character tries to write a new story for the periodic storytelling gatherings of Maithili writers that continue throughout the night. He plans it, then changes its sequence; meanwhile, his experiences, encounters, and episodes from life take shape as a narrative.

"A Sikki-Mauni Basket Before a Child's Understanding" (those who see their culture only in the sikki-mauni craft).

Here too the central character describes certain kinds of people: some are adept only at talking, while others actually work and are capable.

"Gruel and Rice in Life, Milk and Rice in Death...!" (disregard during life, glorification after death).

"Gruel and Rice in Life, Milk and Rice in Death...!" (humiliation while living, glorification after death).

At a tea shop, people discuss whether a feast after someone's death can be justified. Eventually the question becomes one of the neglect and mistreatment of people during their lives.

At the tea shop, discussion turns to free benefits offered by the government. One argument is that such benefits can make people idle; but the same reasoning is applied to the effortless possession of ancestral property.

The next discussion centres on benefits provided free by the government. The argument is that these may make people indolent, but an equivalent question arises over the easy inheritance of family wealth.

The discussion moves to seasonal unemployment. In a town, a person can live by a single skill, whereas in a village many skills are needed to earn a livelihood; one alone is insufficient.

Seasonal unemployment is then discussed. A single skill may support a livelihood in the city, but in the village several skills are required; one skill is not enough.

46. The International Presentation of Maithili Literature and Parallel Literary Discourse

Abstract

The Diorama International Film Festival is scheduled to take place from 30 November to 4 December. Venue: Instituto Cervantes, Hanuman Mandir Road, Connaught Place, New Delhi. https://www.diorama.in/
https://watch.diorama.in/story-market/
https://watch.diorama.in/story/the-science-of-words/
DIORAMA 2022 PRESENTS
Title: The Science of Words—three Maithili stories translated into English by the author himself.

Keywords: Literature · International · Presentation · Parallel · Discourse · Poetry · Necessity

Editorial for the New Issue

1

First Time for Maithili

The Diorama International Film Festival is to be held from 30 November to 4 December at Instituto Cervantes, Hanuman Mandir Road, Connaught Place, New Delhi.
https://www.diorama.in/
https://watch.diorama.in/story-market/
https://watch.diorama.in/story/the-science-of-words/
DIORAMA 2022 PRESENTS
Title: The Science of Words—three Maithili stories translated into English by the author himself.
About the author: Gajendra Thakur is the editor of Videha.
Synopsis: The Sun generally occupies the fifth sign of the zodiac from 16 August to 16 September. This is considered an appropriate time for drying things, for the Sun's intense light and heat reach the Earth during this period. During the period of the fifth sign, palm leaves are dried in the sunshine. This forms part of Milu's father's annual conservation plan, through which life is to be breathed into the palm-leaf manuscripts once

again.
Access procedure: After pressing the 'Register' button above and making payment, a confirmation email arrives and access to the platform is activated. Use the registered email address to log in; the system sends an OTP to that address. If you cannot log in despite having registered, check the registered email for extra spaces or characters, allow time for the activation of a newly purchased pass, or contact the support team at festival (at) diorama.in.

The Diorama International Film Festival is to be held from 30 November to 4 December at Instituto Cervantes, Hanuman Mandir Road, Connaught Place, New Delhi. https://www.diorama.in/ https://watch.diorama.in/story-market/ https://watch.diorama.in/story/the-science-of-words/ The title presented at DIORAMA 2022 is The Science of Words (three Maithili stories translated into English by the author himself). About the author: Gajendra Thakur edits Videha. Synopsis: The Sun generally remains in the fifth sign of the zodiac between 16 August and 16 September. When something needs drying, the Sun's strongest light and heat fall upon the Earth during this period. In this fifth-sign period, Milu's father places palm leaves in the sunlight as part of his yearly preservation plan—as though attempting to fill these leaves with life once more. Procedure: Step 1—press the 'Register' button above and pay; upon completion of payment, a confirmation email will arrive and access to the platform will be provided within an hour. Step 2—enter, for login, the same registered email address that you supplied during registration. Step 3—the system will send an OTP to that registered address; enter the correct OTP to gain access to all the content. Step 4—if you still cannot enter the website after registering, (a) use your registered email address without additional spaces or characters; (b) if you have only recently bought a pass, allow at least sixty minutes for activation; (c) contact the support team at festival (at) diorama.in.

Gajendra Thakur's Commentary on Rajdev Mandal

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

T. K. Oommen writes in the chapter 'Linguistic Diversity' in Sociology (1988), p. 291, National Law School of India University/Bar Council of India Trust: 'The Maithili region is dominated economically and culturally by Brahmins; if a separate Maithili state comes into existence, they may readily establish themselves as the political elite as well. This would not be to the advantage or liking of other castes—those traditionally influential

as well as those presently emerging. Consequently, although these groups belong to the Maithili-speaking community, they may oppose a separate Maithili state. Such opposition adversely affects the development of numerous languages.'

T. K. Oommen further writes: 'Even after a language has been declared separate from Hindi, it may continue to be regarded as a dialect of Hindi. For example, both Grierson, who conducted the classic Linguistic Survey of India, and S. K. Chatterjee, a leading national scholar of linguistics, made it clear that Maithili was an independent language; yet it continued to be treated as a dialect of Hindi.' (Ibid., p. 293.)

A reference to parallel literature may be found in the Vedas, where 'Narāśaṃsī' is mentioned as a form of parallel literature.

An indication of parallel literature may also be found in the Vedas, where 'Narāśaṃsī' is referred to as a form of parallel literature.

The need for parallel literature in Maithili arose from the continued intervention of public and private academies in literature and literary dignity: the Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy in Delhi, the Maithili Academy in Patna, the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi, and Nepal's Prajñā Pratiṣṭhān, all government institutions. Besides these academies, the so-called literary organisations receiving recognition from the Sahitya Akademi became instruments for asserting control over Maithili literature's public space. Financial support received by these bodies and by other narrow organisations produced, in Maithili's name, a mode of representation that, in the original author's judgment, was mediocre and did not represent the wider literary community.

The necessity for parallel literature in Maithili arose from the continuous assaults upon literature and identity by governmental and private academies, including the Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy of Delhi, the Maithili Academy of Patna, the Sahitya Akademi of Delhi, and the Prajñā Pratiṣṭhān of Nepal; these are all governmental institutions. In addition to these academies, so-called literary associations recognised by the Sahitya Akademi continued to exert pressure upon Maithili literature and its dignity and became a principal means of keeping the language's literary field under their control. Financial assistance to these bodies and other narrow organisations continued to construct, in the name of Maithili, a representative image that was average and inconsistent with the actual diversity of society.

The Videha Maithili Literary Movement and a Parallel History of Maithili Literature

For this reason, the recording of those sections of society that had been absent, neglected, and left without representation began. Enriched by a substantial vocabulary and direct experience, this writing intervened transformatively in the literature and art of Maithili-speaking society. The insistence on excellence took the place of mediocrity, and native speakers experienced the real potential of Maithili. The effort to write a parallel history of Maithili literature arose because supposedly mainstream, mediocre literature, sustained by private and government institutions—literature with a limited actual readership and limited acceptance within Maithili-speaking society—continued to be presented by the academies as representative literature. Journals such as Muse India (www.museindia.com) were also employed for this restricted form of representation, while government radio and television stations continued to project the same mediocre image of Maithili literature.

Rajdev Mandal—Poet and Novelist

'Unceasingly Flowing Tears'—a Maithili poem by Shri Rajdev Mandal, from the poetry collection Ambarā.

'Continuously Falling Tears'—a poem by Rajdev Mandal from his poetry collection Ambarā.

tears like a river
always keep flowing
and in the waters of those tears
people plunge
some feel cold
and some feel hot
some say wow!
and some feel bad.
but my blind-and-deaf companion
does not care,
his tears go on flowing all the time
but after a while his tears ceased to flow
perhaps the store of his tears is now exhausted
or
is she storing it!?

Verse is not the most popular literary genre among the general public, although some readers appreciate it seriously. Those engaged in popularising a language such as Sanskrit employ simple Sanskrit prose and translate short stories and novels from other Indian languages into

accessible Sanskrit. In such circumstances, poetry is translated less frequently because its readership is extremely small. Where so few people speak a language that camps must be organised to teach its spoken form, translating poetry may be considered a less useful deployment of resources: this is the question raised by the original commentary.

Verse is not a popular genre, although some readers value it. Volunteers engaged in popularising a language like Sanskrit employ simple Sanskrit prose. Stories and novels from other Indian languages are translated into simple Sanskrit; poetry generally is not, because its readership is very small. When the number of speakers of a language becomes so small that camps must be held to teach people how to speak it, the translation of verse into that language may be regarded as a misuse of resources.

The situation of Maithili is growing serious. If we imagine a state of affairs in which no villages remain, the number of Maithili speakers could become almost zero. People would speak Maithili only at seminars and meetings. Even now, instruction in pronunciation and the enrichment of vocabulary seem necessary even for Maithili writers and singers.

What, then, is the purpose of writing verse in this language? What need does it meet? Some people write poetry because they lack time, since other genres demand more of it. When this becomes the reason offered for writing poetry, the situation is still more serious.

In these circumstances, an incident in the neighbourhood, a personal ambition, a dig at another person, or a travel account—all become subjects for verse. But why not use prose for such subjects? A story can be adapted into a play for performance; but what purpose is served by turning prose into poetry?

For those acquainted with what is called the desiccated mainstream of Maithili literature, the answer is clear and simple. The readers of such transformed verse are generally restricted to critics within the same faction. Poets proclaimed great write their own praise, interpreting the call for self-reliance in this way: why depend on someone else? They attach long prose introductions to their poetry collections and themselves declare their poetry great and epoch-making.

Who will understand the worth of creating verse? Unless personal worldly experience sinks into the deepest reaches of the mind, rhythmic expression alone will not make great poetry. However abstract spiritual or otherworldly thought may be, it cannot captivate readers unless it connects with earthly life and becomes relevant—whether or not it possesses metre, belongs to a factional ideology, or borrows ideological crutches. Human beings need food, clothing, and shelter first; spiritual reflection and other needs follow. The Buddha asked people engrossed in a

celebration: if death is inevitable and you know it, how can you celebrate so unconcernedly? Similarly, contemporary Maithili poets see the linguistic, cultural, and economic ground slipping from under their feet, yet instead of recognising that reality they attempt to insert various 'isms' into national and international events. They produce literature from a position of supposed guardianship over marginalised classes and indigenous peoples, wanting to become their saviours. Such literature therefore fails to acquire a sharp impact.

> With drops of blood falling,
> the earth has become newly bathed.
> The bird then asks
> Asks from its heart
> in the dense and terrible darkness of the night approaching,
> will my species survive?

...Then this enters my blood, and the blood begins to flow faster. Does this question concern the species of poetry to which the poet belongs, or the species of that bird? Understanding such a poem requires neither the endorsement of a partisan critic nor a self-absorbed preface, a literary clique, or the crutches of an ideology.

...Then that experience enters the blood and quickens its flow. Is this the species of the poet's poetry, or that of the bird? Such a poem needs neither a factional critic's approval nor a self-congratulatory introduction—neither a cartel nor ideological crutches.

Excellence is therefore indispensable to poetry. Its foundation should be language and culture. There is no need to import a plot or subject from outside as an act of charity towards poetry. Neither are artificially imported emotions needed—particularly when language and culture are disappearing and the regional economy is weakening; such imports remain merely superficial discoveries.

A good poem may be written on any subject—the Buddha's concerns, humanity's future, solace for the heart, language, culture, or the economy. Otherwise, people will have to take refuge with sham preachers, and the day may come when camps have to be organised to teach Maithili. Images, too, must transform naturally; otherwise it will be necessary to manufacture an artificial environment for the poet, a separate stage for poetry, a contrived vocabulary, and training camps for ideology. People would have to be trained in that artificial system. The poets of the supposedly desiccated mainstream seem occupied with precisely this undertaking.

The rhythm, rise, and fall of the Maithili language; the cultural and professional skills of a working society filled with self-confidence; the

strength of a cooperative way of life; cultural conventions, politics, everyday conduct, social values, ethics, economic conditions, and adaptation within a flood-affected economy; religion and philosophy—all these should constitute subjects of Maithili poetry. Without this breadth, poetry will become one-sided, grow crooked and take root in its distortion, and finally remain no more than a dead object fit to be hung in a frame.

The making of poetry is a necessity—the hunger for literary creation, satisfied through the act of creating. The time to question the need for writing poetry and the purposes of different poetic forms may be when the people of Mithila begin attending camps to learn Maithili; only then might we discuss the futility of writing poetry in the language. But the poet must remain alert so that such a day never arrives. Rajdev Mandal exemplifies this vigilance; hence his collection Ambarā became one of the finest collections of its genre during the first decade of the twenty-first century. Vasundharā is the next step. The excellence of Rajdev Mandal's verse is grounded in language and culture. He needs neither imported subjects nor imported emotions. His imagery finds expression through a rich vocabulary. For Rajdev Mandal, poetry is not merely an option but a creative hunger and a necessity of literary existence: emotion moves into rhythm and becomes poetry.

'I Shall Stay with You'—from Ambarā

Crying, calling
My throat dried
The lips dried
As if I was thirsty
The corpses all around
Are laughing at me
no one is listening to my voice
Where has went
My society
it was necessary to break
The conservatism
Turning of direction
For the future
you are all great yourselves
leave quarrelling behind and move forward
no obstacle will be able to stop this
I have committed no great crime
respected ones, come here
Do not get angry

now I shall break no rule
now I shall trouble none of you
Keep your kingdom
I want neither the ceremonial turban nor the throne
now I shall not change my colours
I shall live peacefully with you all.

Rajdev Mandal—Storyteller

Nāgārjun-Yātrī's Pāro—leaving aside the separate question of whether it was originally written in Maithili or translated into Maithili by the author himself from Hindi—presents a direct picture of the declining culture of the Maithil Brahmin society of its time. It depicts the social and cultural condition of that period. Rajdev Mandal's novel Hamar Ṭol is an account of direct experience, written from within Mithila's Dhanuk community and set in the particular social and cultural circumstances of that community. The author encompasses belief, unreasoning conventions, social reform, love, hatred, hope, and despair. After Lalit, a void becomes visible. The so-called mainstream Maithili writers became trapped in the labyrinth of their chosen subjects; darkness enveloped the literary landscape, and the way out seemed difficult. The original criticism considers Hamar Ṭol an important intervention in this void.

Nāgārjun-Yātrī's Pāro—setting aside whether it was originally written in Maithili or translated by its author himself from Hindi—gives direct experience of the declining culture of Maithil Brahmin society in its own time. It portrays that period's social and cultural situation. Rajdev Mandal's novel Hamar Ṭol offers a direct account of the life of the Dhanuk caste of Mithila in its particular social and cultural conditions. The writer includes belief—sometimes irrational—social reform, love, hatred, hope, and despair. A void emerged after Lalit. The so-called mainstream Maithili writers were trapped in the maze of their chosen subjects; darkness settled over the literary scene, and finding a way out seemed difficult, while progress appeared almost impossible.

Rajdev Mandal's Hamar Ṭol corrects, through firsthand experience, the secondhand account offered by Lalit in Pṛthvīputra; as a result, the parallel current carries the main literary current forward with it and renders it relevant.

As a realist, the storyteller seems almost compelled to make the ending tragic. He refuses to see certain struggles, or cannot see them, or perhaps no one can; nevertheless, he certainly describes those struggles.

A fight broke out between the crow and the myna. No one saw the fight; only the tree saw it. The tree saw much else, too, yet remained silent.

A fight began between a crow and a myna. No one witnessed it; only the tree did. The tree saw much more, but even then remained silent.'

The complexity and entanglement of this silence could be presented with refinement through the direct experience of an unseen event rather than through an indirect account. For this reason, the novel has established a place for itself in the history of Maithili literature.

Rajdev Mandal regards the following five stories as his finest:

Rajdev Mandal considers the following five stories his best:

Avāk (Speechless)

Bechuā's Sweater

The Ghost of the Election

and Rakhbār (The Watchman).

The first story, 'Rusal Bauā' (The Sulking Boy), was written for the eighty-second Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray. This is an all-night story-reading programme held every three months in Mithila's villages, in which storytellers read their new, unpublished stories and other writers offer critical evaluations; it runs from evening until dawn. On that occasion it was decided that only stories for children would be read, and the event took place in my village. Rajdev Mandal's story was assigned to Nārāyaṇī for review. Narayanji remarked that the story recalled Premchand's celebrated 'Īdgāh'. Phekan's son is angry; he wants new clothes and will not go to the Durga Puja fair without them. Amit, the son of Dhirendra Babu, has new clothes. Dhirendra Babu is prosperous and Phekan is poor, but Phekan's son surpasses Amit in every sphere, whether study or play. Phekan and his wife discuss the matter; she accuses Phekan of failing even in his responsibility towards their son. The boy overhears them and finally consoles his father.

The first story, 'Rusal Bauā', was written for the eighty-second Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray, an all-night gathering for reading stories, held every three months in Mithila's villages, where storytellers present new and unpublished work. Other writers comment critically on the stories read, and the programme continues from dusk until morning. This time it was decided to read only children's stories; the gathering was held in my village. Rajdev Mandal's story was assigned to Nārāyaṇī for review. Narayanji said that it reminded him of Premchand's famous 'Īdgāh'. The plot unfolds thus: Phekan's son is sulking. He wants new clothes or else he will not attend the Durga Puja fair. Amit, Dhirendra Babu's son, has new clothes. Dhirendra Babu is wealthy, Phekan poor; yet in study and play alike Phekan's son is ahead of Amit. Phekan talks with his wife, who

accuses him of failing to fulfil even his duty towards the boy. The son hears everything and ultimately comforts his father.

'Avāk' opens with several humorous moments. Jitu arrives at his in-laws' house, where his brother-in-law introduces him to a friend. This man appears to be associated with a band of dacoits and had once saved Jitu's life.

'Bechuā's Sweater' raises the questions of bonded labour and poverty, while hinting at caste-based thinking within the police force. The boy who works in a tea stall is a child labourer. The story also shows the corruption deeply entrenched in the police system.

'The Ghost of the Election' comments on elections and democracy. The central character relates a sequence of events, and at the end it becomes clear that all of it was a dream. This narrative device is exceptionally effective.

'Rakhbār' tells the story of Musba, a village watchman. His son hands a spear to his wife—Musba's daughter-in-law—and says that if Musba quarrels, she should pierce his body with it. Musba, feared as a terror outside, is kept under control inside his home. The subsequent wordplay leads to an episode concerning Sumanā, who resists when Musba attempts to behave obscenely towards her.

All these stories contain words and incidents absent from mainstream literature. The pulse of life amid poverty, sadness, and the cultural tools of everyday existence—such narratives were seldom heard in this form before the arrival of storytellers of the parallel tradition.

Issue 88 of Muse India (November–December 2019), http://museindia.com/Home/PastIssue, presents Maithili literature in an extremely weak form. It nevertheless claims to provide a representative review of Maithili literature, whereas it represents only what has been called the 'desiccated main drain', in accordance with the outlook of the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi. It is hoped that Muse India will improve its presentation and publish an independent issue devoted to the parallel tradition of Maithili literature.

47. Folk Culture, Literature, Book Criticism, and the Parallel Perspective

Abstract

The Rgveda had the Hotṛ priest, the Sāmaveda the Udgātṛ, the Yajurveda the Adhvaryu, and the Atharvaveda the Brahman; together with their assistants there were altogether seventeen kinds of priest during the Vedic period. How, then,

has the Brahmin now become the sole priest? In Odisha, the title 'Hota' still exists; there, Brahmins belonging to the Ṛgvedic, Sāmavedic, and Yajurvedic traditions do not establish marital relations with the Atharvavedic Brahmins of what is called the violent (!) Pippalāda Saṃhitā.

Keywords: Culture · Work · Criticism · Parallel · Perspective · Also · Doing

Editorial for the New Issue

1

The Ṛgveda had its Hotṛ priest, the Sāmaveda its Udgātṛ, the Yajurveda its Adhvaryu, and the Atharvaveda its Brahman. With their assisting priests there were altogether seventeen kinds of Vedic priest. How is it that now there is only one Brahmin priest? Even today the title 'Hota' survives in Odisha, where Ṛgvedic, Sāmavedic, and Yajurvedic Brahmins do not intermarry with the Atharvavedic Brahmins of the supposedly violent (!) Pippalāda Saṃhitā. In southern India, priests from several tribal communities became Brahmins. For the worship of Kālībandī, or for bhagait and phulhāsi rites, a priest comes; that person can be a non-Brahmin or a Brahmin. Someone speaking without fieldwork will ask how a Brahmin can serve a gahbar shrine or perform as a bhagat. But in the village of Rudrapur (via Tulapatganj, Madhubani district) a Brahmin bhagait performs service at the gahbar. Among the Satar (Santhal) community spread across Mithila, a Murmu pandit rhythmically recites an invocation from a text said to date from the Indus Valley civilisation; members of that community can tell you about it. Dalit discourse repeatedly discusses the killing of Śambūka in the Uttarakāṇḍa of the Vālmīki Rāmāyaṇa: because Śambūka practised austerities, a complaint was made lest he rise in status, and Lord Rama killed him to resolve that complaint. In the course of telling stories in Puruṣaparīkṣā, Vidyapati is made to pronounce an authorial judgment that Rajput women are immoral. Both cases resemble the alleged Atharvavedic statement that anyone may seize the hand of a Śūdra's wife and take her away without consent. You will find this statement on social media and the internet; search the original Atharvaveda as long as you like and you will find no reference. Whoever makes the allegation incites trouble and disappears without providing a citation. You are left bewildered: the burden of proof falls not upon the accuser but upon you. Your energy is wasted, although the internet eventually makes correction possible and the text is not corrupted. Let us first return to Puruṣaparīkṣā. Would Vidyapati, the court poet writing in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa, have had the audacity to write such a thing about women belonging to his royal patron's caste? If a later copyist with a corrupted mind altered the text in accordance with his own feelings, today's commentator and translator ought to explain the matter

in a note. Did Rama kill Śambūka, or did a malicious copyist who raised an accusation against Śambūka kill him? Now consider the Atharvaveda. It says: 'O woman, I am the Sāmaveda and you are the Ṛgveda; O bride, I take your hand for prosperity.' Moreover, the Atharvaveda and Sāṃkhya are associated with the Vrātya tradition. The Vrātyas, who had not recited the Gāyatrī mantra for three generations, were accordingly regarded as forest dwellers, moving through forests and wildernesses. There was also a rite resembling what is now called 'ghar vāpasī', the Vrātyastoma, intended to bring the Vrātyas of the parallel stream back. Elsewhere they are described as physically and sexually violent or given to intoxication, but the Atharvaveda portrays them as yogis. Other accounts depict them as guardians of truth and physicians devoted to Śiva. Yet even Atharvavedic Brahmins were called violent. Corrupt copyists introduced interpolations into the Vedas as well, which linguists are now detecting. In interpreting mantras, Maharshi Patañjali offered the scientific maxim 'yac chabda āha tad asmākaṃ pramāṇam': what the word or expression of the mantra says is evidence for us. How this later came to mean that the Veda alone is authoritative evidence, I do not know. Vedic literature contained work useful to ordinary people and not bound to a particular side. 'Fill all Brahmins, Kṣatriyas, Vaiśyas, and Śūdras with radiance, and fill me with that same radiance'—this is found in the Yajurveda.

Sita arrives and wants to cross the Kamala river, but the boatman says that he wants a reward—and what reward but Sita's sister-in-law? Sita replies, 'I have given her; enjoy her for ages upon ages.' Sita's parental home is Mithila: would a boatman not even exchange this much teasing with her? These lines are sung by the Dūdhvaṃśī community of Mithila; I heard them from Korail and Budhan's mother.

The Gidarmārā have their own language, you know. People call them Gidarmārā and Magahiyā Dom, but they call themselves Banjara and their speech the Banjara language. Try calling them Gidarmārā to their faces: they will quarrel with you. Banjaras believe that the world is governed by good and evil.

Settlements of destitute beggars have appeared in towns, and these neighbourhoods have no caste distinctions. Near Simra, at Sukhent, there is a large tented settlement of Banjaras: it is built and dispersed, built and dispersed. Satar communities live to the east and south of Madhepur, south of Duālak, in Karharā and Ṭaṛhiyā. These Santhals are skilled with the bow and arrow.

Writing about the Maithili folktale 'Ekṭā Cinmā Kheliyau Rao Bhaiyā', Subhash Chandra Yadav says: 'The Manusmṛti says that quietly plucking someone's flower does not constitute theft; similarly, eating a single grain belonging to someone else is no crime. This is the tale's inner voice. The

story establishes the proposition that every life has equal value. The helpless and the poor also have the right to live. There should be a space for them, too, in this world.' The Manusmṛti is so tolerant at one point, and its vocabulary is so close to modern legal terminology that it seems to have no legal gap whatsoever; yet cruel statements, too, have been inserted into it.

In translations of the Vedas into foreign languages, the names of the ṛṣis have been removed, though they may still be found in the originals. Among the seers of Vedic hymns are women and Śūdra sages as well; who, then, inserted compositions against women and Śūdras? Why should a Śūdra sage such as Kavaṣa Ailūṣa, a seer of Vedic verses, or a woman such as Apālā, also a Vedic seer, be made to stand at the margins? In the Vedas, however, three things appear with each hymn number: ṛṣi, deity, and metre. We call the ṛṣi a seer, but efforts were made to misuse even this designation. The Vedic sages call themselves poets, and they call the deities poets as well. All Vedic literature is the verbal embodiment of this poetic consciousness. Spiritual awareness there is elevated to divine consciousness and expressed in language concerning the physical world. Indeed, even at that time those who recited verses together over the course of the year were compared in the Atharvaveda to croaking frogs welcoming Parjanya. This suggests that the possibility of a dissenting voice in song was acknowledged; the Ṛgveda also has a frog hymn. Patañjali's scientific maxim in mantra interpretation, 'yac chabda āha tad asmākaṃ pramāṇam', means that what the words or expressions of a mantra say is authoritative for us. How did this come to mean that the Veda alone is authoritative? I do not know. For me the mantra has its ṛṣi and its deity; both are poets, authors of the hymn, and this is my evidence. Janaka organised a philosophical disputation with a thousand cows as the prize. Yājñavalkya was about to depart with the cows when Gārgī's questioning began. She pressed him with further questions based on his replies. Yājñavalkya warned her not to ask so many questions that her head might split into pieces. Yet Gārgī still asked: 'Under whose dominion are time and duration?' Yājñavalkya replied: 'Under that of the Imperishable.'

Even today, the editor of a journal issued by Chetna Samiti, a so-called literary association recognised by the Sahitya Akademi, makes additions and omissions in articles under the influence of Brahmanical conventions. In 'Pachpaniyā Maithili', Subhash Chandra Yadav writes about this editor: 'Dr Ramanand Jha "Raman" noted in his notebook: "A Brahmin says, I am a Srotriya; a Solhakan says, I am a Brahmin. What should I say I am?" The contempt expressed for Solhakans in this note is nothing other than a linguistic expression of caste animosity and hatred.' I have continued to raise this same objection to such vocabulary in Mahendra Malangia's plays, but his caste-oriented theatre is intoxicated by something and is unconcerned with the feelings of others. When, moreover, a gentleman

writing a Maithili essay on Lorik in a twentieth-century Sahitya Akademi book says that Lorik rose against the atrocities perpetrated by Śūdras upon Brahmins, and we have already seen the condition of Ramanand Jha 'Raman' and Malangia, why blame their intellectual ancestor Tulsidas, writing during Akbar's reign? Just as Vishnu Sharma, while narrating tales in the Pañcatantra, suddenly becomes cruel towards women and Śūdras without reason, so too does the Rāmcaritmānas. The stories of the Pañcatantra are excellent, yet Vishnu Sharma turns upon women and Śūdras. Narayana Pandit therefore rewrote the same tales under the title Hitopadeśa, a much more practical work. Will Ramanand Jha 'Raman' and Mahendra Malangia apologise and rewrite their compositions? Will the translator of Puruṣaparīkṣā insert a note at the appropriate place explaining that Vidyapati, writing in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa and praised by the king, would hardly have had the audacity to misrepresent the character of Rajput women, and that the passage is the work of a caste-prejudiced copyist? Narayana Pandit, moreover, writes in the Hitopadeśa:

आहार निद्रा भय मैथुनं च सामान्यमेतत् पशुभिर्नराणाम्।
धर्मो हि तेषामधिको विशेषः धर्मेण हीनाः पशुभिः समानाः ॥

Food, sleep, fear, and sexual intercourse are common to human beings and animals alike. The distinguishing quality of human beings is dharma; without it they are no different from animals.

2

The internet has become cyberspace.

But there are dangers there too: viruses, spam, malware, spyware, Trojan horses, and worms.

A virus is like Raktabīja: from one program it produces another, although it too is itself a program. System, stealth, file, and polymorphic viruses are among its types.

A worm is also a virus-like program that spreads through networks.

A Trojan horse is exceedingly cunning: it seems that it will do one thing but instead does quite another. Spyware is an agent of espionage, spying on individuals or organisations. Malware is a collective term for all these—viruses, worms, spyware, and Trojan horses—which damage computers connected to a network. Spam is the mass of unsolicited emails sent to unknown people to persuade them to buy or sell something fraudulent.

Antivirus software restrains such threats. A firewall is the wall of a fortress that keeps hackers or crackers from attacking or taking control of your computer or network.

Finally comes our ethical hacker—the match for all the hackers and crackers—who, for your benefit, tries to break through your antivirus software and firewall. If the attempt succeeds, the ethical hacker strengthens them through better programming and attacks again. Think of it as a mock drill.

Create an image of yourself that good people can love—an image of competence and hard work.

Yet as time passes and we advance, the image many of us hold of ourselves begins to deteriorate. This happens when we pay attention to what others think or say about us. They may supply pretended knowledge, or at times real knowledge, or simply information, but can they give us our own self-image or our abilities? No; more often they do the opposite. Parents and teachers sometimes become involved in this unknowingly, as do friends, society, and relatives. 'This one is more or less attractive; that child's mathematics is better or worse than another's; befriend the clever child or avoid the foolish one; it is because of that person that we won or lost.' Their actions and words do these things, but only when you lend them your ears and your attention.

Success that is truly success—success achieved without compromise—will increase your self-confidence. Failure will discourage you only when it is genuinely failure. How much literature Jacques Derrida's deconstruction brought from below to above, and how much it brought down from above!

Is it success, or is it really success, to steal in the name of creative literature and then obtain awards and money from the disciplinary institutions described by Michel Foucault? And is the lifelong steadfastness of someone gentle yet firm, like Subhash Chandra Yadav, and the price paid for it, success or failure?

Therefore maintain your confidence and keep your discipline unwavering. Continue to increase your abilities every day; if a day passes without any increase in your competence, consider that day wasted. Cultivate equanimity and self-confidence. If you possess these qualities, you belong to the parallel current: you are welcome.

Rise early in the morning and do household work as well: this will make you responsible and self-reliant. Do not be ashamed to ask for help when a difficulty arises, and help others with their difficulties. It is hard to stand before a powerful enemy; courage, a clear understanding of right and wrong, and truth are needed for it. Never lay down your arms against injustice. Shouting alone will make no one listen; demonstrate through action. Weeping and lamentation will achieve nothing: act, and practise what you preach.

There is much that is false on the internet too. Neither create nor spread fake news, and protect yourself against cybercriminals.

Do not frighten or mistreat those weaker or younger than yourself. If anyone behaves in this way towards you, lodge a complaint.

Like the Jaipur Foot (an artificial limb) and the smokeless stove, parallel literature too is being pursued through invention and selfless work, without greed for money or prizes, so that we may build a better society and carry it forward.

Everyone possesses some skill, such as the skill of playing the pipahī, a wind instrument. If you doubt it, try blowing into one yourself. It takes years of training. The same is true of folk dance and performance, and of knowledge connected with wood and clay. Respect these arts.

Welcome only the development that does not destroy the environment. Plant ten trees for every tree you cut down.

Are you afraid to undertake a task alone, even the smallest task? Yet companionship and support will not always be available.

Forget the past, whether it has been good or bad.

Some friends and organisations make you unhappy, provoke anger, and discourage you. The time has come to bid them farewell. Good days are still to come; how long can bad times endure? The lessons learned in adversity have lasting value and help us avoid repeating our mistakes. It is also necessary to pause amid work and reflect, and to visit one's village, relatives, and friends.

Be prepared to see the rainbow after the rain. There can be magic every day; it happens when you help at least one person each day. Keep writing down and collecting your thoughts. Never skip breakfast; sleep seven or eight hours, and eat food that is good for your body. If the mind remains restless, meditate, paint, read, talk with a friend, travel, or dance to music.

Life is priceless: respect every moment. Work hard without complaint, even—and all the more—when your efforts bring failure. Take one step each day towards the dream you have seen, towards your goal. If this gives you joy, you belong to the parallel current: you are welcome.

A harsh laugh that does not reach the eyes, used to conceal anger, reveals no happiness. It is not the laughter that follows a humorous anecdote, nor the smile with which one makes another person a friend and assures them that one poses no threat. We should help the elderly and the ill, and assist people and countries affected by war and natural disasters; such assistance will never be meaningless. You should have a clear objective before you, and attain it through diligence and devotion. Learn to speak up against

those who inflict injustice and suffering, and be grateful to those who serve humanity selflessly. We should attend to persons with disabilities and remain sensitive to their needs. Beyond disability, people possess many qualities: we should recognise those qualities and support them in securing their rights. According to the World Health Organization, fifteen per cent of the world's population has a disability. The first Indian census of persons with disabilities was undertaken in 2001 and recorded only 2.1 per cent; that figure is not credible. There will always be pressure upon you to resemble your colleagues and friends. Do not yield to it. Develop your own personality.

It is not good to lose your life for the sake of a joke or an amusement.

Chemicals used in fields pollute the environment. Produce grown with organic materials and without chemical substances is healthier and tastier.

People with little self-respect need the approval of others in order to feel good. This applies to those who post on Facebook and count the 'likes'. A number of incidents have occurred in which people taking selfies fell into ravines or from roofs and died. Of course, selfies can also be used for a worthwhile purpose, such as a selfie with one's daughter.

Understand the value of time. Useless committees and meetings, especially reactionary organisations, can waste a great deal of it. If you cannot arrive at the appointed hour, do not forget to apologise. Money has driven us away from nature. The Indigenous Abenaki people of Canada, who live on their reserved land at Odanak, have created beautiful sayings about the environment: 'Only when the last tree is cut, every stream poisoned, and every fish killed will you understand that you cannot eat money.'

Live simply, so that the environment is not harmed, and remain connected with nature.

Live in harmony with one another—not only with people but also with cattle, birds, all living creatures, nature, and the rivers.

And if you do this, you belong to the parallel current: you are welcome.

No one is perfect, but everyone can try to become better. We should strive to remain truthful, honest, and compassionate. Everyone should work to keep this world a good place in which to live.

We should read widely and keep learning new things.

3

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

Pseudocriticism in Maithili and the Case of Kamalanand Jha

In the original author's view, the title of Kamalanand Jha's book Maithili Novel: Time, Society and Questions (2021) creates a misleading impression. He regards it as a collection of supposedly critical essays on a few selected writers from a particular caste. He attacks this 263-page book with sharp satire, suggesting that it will be confined to a few library-bound hardback copies. As a corrective example he cites Gulo, a novel by the non-caste-aligned writer Subhash Chandra Yadav, which Kamalanand Jha, in the author's opinion, disposes of in two lines without having read it. Those two lines are quoted below. The critic urges readers to read Gulo first; it is said to be available in the Videha archive with Subhash Chandra Yadav's permission at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

'The novel's weakness is the author's political prejudice. Partisanship towards a particular political position does not do justice to a literary work.'

The original reviewer responds that in a novel where politics is not even remotely the subject, the question of 'political prejudice' or 'partisanship towards a particular political position' does not arise. He finds political commitments in the writing of Dhūmketu and Yātrī, but argues that Subhash Chandra Yadav's Voṭ (2022)—also said to be available with the author's permission in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm—avoids one-sided political insistence through its narrative technique, although its subject is political. The critic also mentions his own Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav, said to be available at the same address. The original essay then alleges that Kamalanand Jha writes like a political party's spokesperson and is affected by caste prejudice and a Brahmanical outlook. It also questions the propriety of an assignment for translation work granted by the Sahitya Akademi. The author links these allegations to the concern for social justice in the parallel literary current. One basis for describing Kamalanand Jha as a 'pseudo-critic' is a statement attributed to him: after a journey of almost a century, Gaurinath is credited with writing a dignified novel about the dreams, struggles, and ironies of inter-caste marriage. The original reviewer asks why such credit overlooks Sushil's Gambālī (1982), whose opening explicitly supports widow remarriage and inter-caste marriage and which is said to be available in the Videha archive. The essay uses this dispute to reread Sushil's literary world. It next calls Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Dui Pāṭan Ke Bīc Meṃ a historical biography of the Kosi river, citing his other books on rivers:

Bandinī Mahānandā, Bāgmatī Kī Sadgati!, Nā Ghāṭ Nā Ghar, Kamalā Nadī, Bhutahī Nadī..., The Kamla River and People on Collision Course, Bhutahi Balan—Story of a Ghost River and Engineering Witchcraft, and Refugees of the Kosi Embankments. The original essay makes a serious allegation that Pankaj Jha Parashar committed literary plagiarism, paragraph by paragraph, from Dinesh Kumar Mishra's writings, and alleges that Kamalanand Jha endorsed this activity as 'research'. The author supplies screenshots comparing the Hindi original with the Maithili passages. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's education—Civil Engineering at IIT Kharagpur (1968) and an M.Tech in Structural Engineering (1970)—is mentioned to underline his expertise in river studies. The original essay connects this controversy to social justice and critical accountability in the parallel literary tradition.

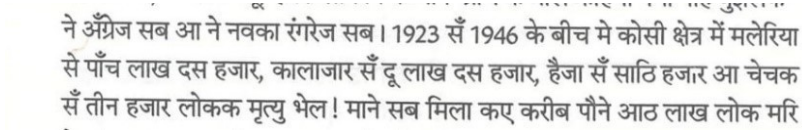
All of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's books are now said to be available in the Videha archive with his permission:

http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm

An incident involving Bill Gates is recalled here. Asked whether the introduction of the Xbox in India had been delayed out of fear of piracy, he is quoted as saying that Microsoft did not postpone product launches because of such fears. Using this as a metaphor, the original author declares that the Videha archive (http://www.videha.co.in/archive.htm) will continue to be enriched despite risks. The presence of one or two rotten fish in a pond does not make every fish rotten; the 'fishermen' of the parallel current have continued, and will continue, to remove the rotten ones.

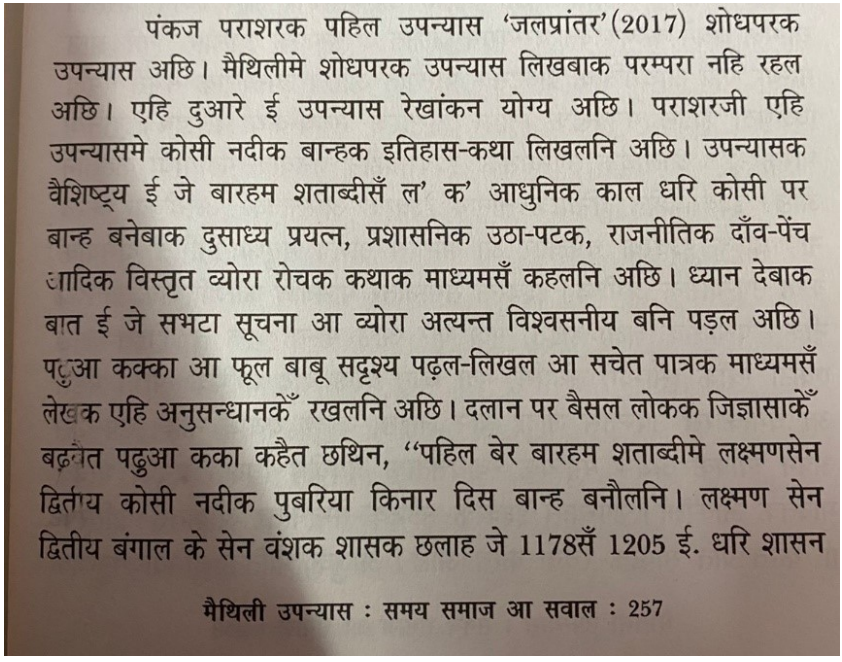
A Final Challenge to Factional Pseudoliterary Criticism in Maithili

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's original Dui Pāṭan Ke Bīc Meṃ... (2006) states that between 1923 and 1946, 510,000 people died of malaria in the Kosi region, 210,000 of kala-azar, 60,000 of cholera, and 3,000 of smallpox—a total of 783,000. The original essay then places beside this an extract from Pankaj Jha Parashar's Jalprāntar (2017, p. 103), makes a direct comparison, and advances an allegation of literary plagiarism.


ने अँग्रेज सब आ ने नवका रंगरेज सब। 1923 सँ 1946 के बीच मे कोसी क्षेत्र में मलेरिया
से पाँच लाख दस हजार, कालाजार सँ दू लाख दस हजार, हैजा सँ साठि हजार आ चेचक
सँ तीन हजार लोकक मृत्यु भेल! माने सब मिला कए करीब पौने आठ लाख लोक मरि

English translation of visible documentary excerpt: Visible excerpt: '...Neither the British nor the new British. Between 1923 and 1946, in the Kosi region, 510,000 people died of malaria, 210,000 of kala-azar, 60,000 of cholera, and 3,000 of smallpox: altogether nearly eight hundred thousand people died...'

An original passage in Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Dui Pāṭan Ke Bīc Meṃ... (2006) states that in the twelfth century, King Lakshman II built an embankment on the Kosi river in Bihar, for which the people conferred upon him the title 'Vīr' and called the embankment 'Vīr Bāndh'. Remains of it are said to be visible about five kilometres south of Bhimnagar in Supaul district. Dr Francis Buchanan (1810–11) conjectured that it was possibly the outer defensive wall of a fort, because it stretched for roughly thirty-two kilometres along the western bank from the Tilyuga to the confluence with the Dhaus river. Dr W. W. Hunter (1877) disagreed. Citing local accounts, he concluded that it was not a fort wall, but could not establish its true purpose. The general belief was that the embankment may have been built to prevent the Kosi from flowing westwards and that construction had stopped abruptly. After this passage the original essay quotes passages from Kamalanand Jha's Maithili Novel, Time, Society and Questions (pp. 257–58) to compare what it describes as Pankaj Jha Parashar's plagiarised material.

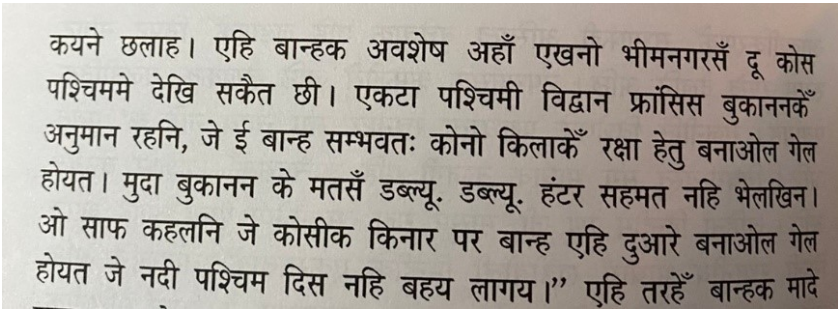


पंकज पराशरक पहिल उपन्यास 'जलप्रांतर' (2017) शोधपरक उपन्यास अछि। मैथिलीमे शोधपरक उपन्यास लिखबाक परम्परा नहि रहल अछि। एहि दुआरे ई उपन्यास रेखांकन योग्य अछि। पराशरजी एहि उपन्यासमे कोसी नदीक बान्हक इतिहास-कथा लिखलनि अछि। उपन्यासक वैशिष्ट्य ई जे बारहम शताब्दीसँ ल' क' आधुनिक काल धरि कोसी पर बान्ह बनेबाक दुसाध्य प्रयत्न, प्रशासनिक उठा-पटक, राजनीतिक दाँव-पेंच आदिक विस्तृत व्योरा रोचक कथाक माध्यमसँ कहलनि अछि। ध्यान देबाक बात ई जे सभटा सूचना आ व्योरा अत्यन्त विश्वसनीय बनि पड़ल अछि। पढुआ कक्का आ फूल बाबू सदृश्य पढ़ल-लिखल आ सचेत पात्रक माध्यमसँ लेखक एहि अनुसन्धानकेँ रखलनि अछि। दलान पर बैसल लोकक जिज्ञासाकेँ बढ़बैत पढुआ कका कहैत छथिन, "पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दीमे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मण सेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह जे 1178सँ 1205 ई. धरि शासन

मैथिली उपन्यास : समय समाज आ सवाल : 257

English translation of visible documentary excerpt: Visible excerpt from Maithili Novel: Time, Society and Questions, p. 257: 'Pankaj Parashar's first novel, Jalprāntar (2017), is a research-based novel. There has been no tradition of writing research-based novels in Maithili, and the work is therefore worthy of notice. In this novel Parashar recounts the historical story of the Kosi river's embankments. Its distinctive feature is that he tells, through an engaging narrative, the detailed

history of the daring attempts to construct embankments from the twelfth century to modern times, together with administrative upheavals and political manoeuvres. Notably, the whole body of information and detail seems highly credible. The author presents his research through educated and perceptive characters such as Paḍuā Kakkā and Phul Babu. Arousing the curiosity of people seated in the courtyard, Paḍuā Kakkā says: The first embankment on the Kosi's eastern bank was built in the twelfth century by Lakshman Sen II. Lakshman Sen II was a ruler of Bengal's Sena dynasty, who reigned from 1178 to 1205 CE...'


कयने छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगरसँ दू कोस
पश्चिममे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकाननकेँ
अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह सम्भवतः कोनो किलाकेँ रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल
होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मतसँ डब्ल्यू. डब्ल्यू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन।
ओ साफ कहलनि जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल
होयत जे नदी पश्चिम दिस नहि बहय लागय।" एहि तरहेँ बान्हक मादे

English translation of visible documentary excerpt: Continuation of the visible excerpt: '...completed it. The remains of this embankment can still be seen about two kos west of Bhimnagar. The Western scholar Francis Buchanan conjectured that this embankment may have been constructed to protect a fort. I, however, cannot agree with Buchanan's view. He himself said quite plainly that the embankment built on the Kosi's bank was such that the river would not flow westward. In this way the embankment...'

The original essay presents an excerpt from Pankaj Jha Parashar's Jalprāntar (2017, p. 31) for comparison with Dinesh Kumar Mishra's original writing.

पढ़ुआ कका पछिला गप कें आगाँ बढ़बैत कहलखिन, 'फूल बाबू, कोसी नदीक बेसिन प्राचीन काल सँ मनुक्खक निवास लेल उपयुक्त स्थान रहल अछि। बारहम-तेरहम सदी मे भारत मे जखन कइक टा नदी सुखा गेल, तँ ओहि ठामक पशुचारक समाजक लोक एतय आबि कए बसलाह। तहिये सँ बढ़ैत जनसंख्या आ कोसी नदीक बदलैत प्रवाहक मध्य टकराहटि होमय लागल। नदीक अनियंत्रित धारा कें लोक बाढ़ि बूझय लागल। पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दी मे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह, जे 1178 सँ 1205 ईस्वी धरि शासन कयनें छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगर सँ दू कोस पश्चिम मे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकानन के अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह संभवत: कोनो किला के रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मत सँ डब्लू. डब्लू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलखिन, जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत, जे नदी पच्छिम दिस नहि बह' लागय।' पढ़ुआ कका सँ मुँहजबानी एतेक रास ऐतिहासिक तथ्य सुनियो कए फूल बाबू सहमति मे मूड़ी नहि डोलेलखिन। जाहि सँ ओतय बैसल लोक सबहक उत्सुकता और बढ़ि गेलनि, जे गप मे एहेन कोन तथ्य रहि गेलै जे फूल बाबू संतुष्ट नहि भेलखिन? लोक कें बुझेलनि जे फूल बाबू शास्त्रार्थ के अखड़हा पर माटि फेकि रहल छथिन। पढ़ुआ कका कें आइ जोड़ीदार भेटि गेलनि!

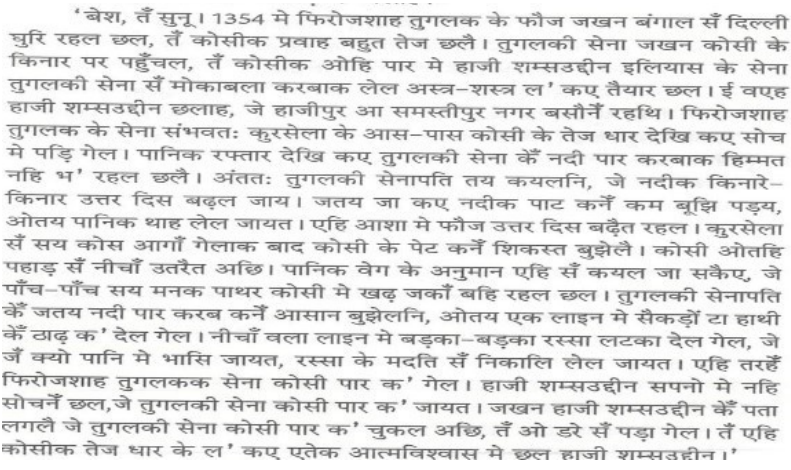
जलप्रांतर / 31

English translation of visible documentary excerpt: Visible excerpt from Jalprāntar, p. 31: 'Increasing the curiosity of those seated in the courtyard, Paḍuā Kakkā said: Phul Babu, the Kosi river had long been a suitable dwelling place for human beings in ancient times. In the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, when several rivers dried up in India, people left their traditional pastoral society and began cultivating land. As the population grew, encroachment upon the Kosi's shifting course increased. People began to suffer from the river's uncontrolled current. Lakshman Sen II built an embankment on the eastern bank of the Kosi for the first time in the twelfth century. Lakshman Sen II was a ruler of Bengal's Sena dynasty, who ruled from 1178 to 1205 CE. The remains of this embankment can still be seen about two kos west of Bhimnagar. The Western scholar Francis Buchanan conjectured that this embankment was perhaps built to defend a fort. But I do not agree with Buchanan. He said explicitly that the embankment on the Kosi's bank was built so that the river would not flow westward. Paḍuā Kakkā then asked: Phul Babu, have you ever heard such a historical fact? Phul Babu shook his head in agreement. The people there turned over in their minds the remarkable history that had lain buried in the

village. Those who understood nothing struck the ground with a stick in the style of Phul Babu's followers. Paḍuā Kakkā's eyes shone brightly.'

In Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Dui Pāṭan Ke Bīc Meṃ... (2006), an incident involving Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army on its return from Bengal to Delhi is recounted to convey the Kosi's formidable power. According to the account, when the Sultan's army reached the Kosi, the forces of Haji Shamsuddin Ilyas stood ready for battle on the opposite bank. This was the same Shamsuddin who is said to have founded the towns of Hajipur and Samastipur. Firoz's army became stranded on the banks of the Kosi near Kursela; the force of the river prevented further movement. Eventually it was decided to travel upstream to the north and search for a place where the river could be crossed. The army travelled about a hundred kos upstream and attempted the crossing around Jiyāran, where the river descends from the hills to the plains. The river was narrower there, but its current was so powerful that stones weighing five hundred maunds were described as floating away like blades of grass. Lines of elephants were stationed on both sides of the crossing and ropes suspended below them so that soldiers swept away by the water could be rescued. Shamsuddin had not believed that the Sultan's army could cross the Kosi; when he heard that it had done so, he withdrew.

The original essay presents an excerpt from Pankaj Jha Parashar's Jalprāntar (2017, p. 105) for comparison with Dinesh Kumar Mishra's account given above.



'बेश, तँ सुनू। 1354 मे फिरोजशाह तुगलक के फौज जखन बंगाल सँ दिल्ली घुरि रहल छल, तँ कोसीक प्रवाह बहुत तेज छलै। तुगलकी सेना जखन कोसी के किनार पर पहुँचल, तँ कोसीक ओहि पार मे हाजी शम्सउद्दीन इलियास के सेना तुगलकी सेना सँ मोकाबला करबाक लेल अस्त्र-शस्त्र ल' कए तैयार छल। ई वएह हाजी शम्सउद्दीन छलाह, जे हाजीपुर आ समस्तीपुर नगर बसौनैं रहथि। फिरोजशाह तुगलक के सेना संभवतः कुरसेला के आस-पास कोसी के तेज धार देखि कए सोच मे पड़ि गेल। पानिक रफ्तार देखि कए तुगलकी सेना कैं नदी पार करबाक हिम्मत नहि भ' रहल छलै। अंततः तुगलकी सेनापति तय कयलनि, जे नदीक किनारे-किनार उत्तर दिस बढ़ल जाय। जतय जा कए नदीक पाट कनैं कम बूझि पड़य, ओतय पानिक थाह लेल जायत। एहि आशा मे फौज उत्तर दिस बढ़ैत रहल। कुरसेला सँ सय कोस आगाँ गेलाक बाद कोसी के पेट कनैं शिकस्त बुझेलै। कोसी ओतहि पहाड़ सँ नीचाँ उतरैत अछि। पानिक वेग के अनुमान एहि सँ कयल जा सकैए, जे पाँच-पाँच सय मनक पाथर कोसी मे खढ़ जकाँ बहि रहल छल। तुगलकी सेनापति कैं जतय नदी पार करब कनैं आसान बुझेलनि, ओतय एक लाइन मे सैकड़ों टा हाथी कैं ठाढ़ क' देल गेल। नीचाँ वला लाइन मे बड़का-बड़का रस्सा लटका देल गेल, जे जँ क्यो पानि मे भासि जायत, रस्सा के मदति सँ निकालि लेल जायत। एहि तरहेँ फिरोजशाह तुगलकक सेना कोसी पार क' गेल। हाजी शम्सउद्दीन सपनो मे नहि सोचनैं छल,जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' जायत। जखन हाजी शम्सउद्दीन कैं पता लगलै जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' चुकल अछि, तँ ओ डरे सँ पड़ा गेल। तँ एहि कोसीक तेज धार के ल' कए एतेक आत्मविश्वास मे छल हाजी शम्सउद्दीन।'

English translation of visible documentary excerpt: Visible excerpt relating to the Kosi crossing: '...Well, Sattu! In 1354, Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army, returning to Delhi after winning Bengal, reached the Kosi river. On the opposite bank of the Kosi, the forces of Haji Shamsuddin Ilyas stood ready for battle. The great river halted the

Sultan's army near Kursela. Haji Shamsuddin, who founded Hajipur and Samastipur, had placed his forces there. The soldiers were anxious and searched for a place to cross. The army went a hundred kos upstream, reaching the region near Jiyāran, where the mountain river enters the plains. Even there the current was extremely powerful. Stones weighing five hundred maunds were swept along in the current like grass. To carry the army across, lines of elephants were placed on both banks and ropes suspended to rescue soldiers who might be swept away. When Shamsuddin heard that Firoz Shah's forces had succeeded in crossing the Kosi, he withdrew.'

(Further screenshots will shortly be updated at this link: http://www.videha.co.in/investigation.htm)

4

My Commentary on Five Short Stories by Narayan Yadav

Five Short Stories by Shri Narayan Yadav

Shri Narayan Yadav regards the following five short stories as his best:

Navkī Putohū (The New Daughter-in-Law)

Sāmpradāyik Sadbhāv (Communal Harmony)

Kanyāk Jingī (A Girl's Life)

Hṛday Parivartan (A Change of Heart)

Gāmak Ektā (Village Unity)

The strength of 'Navkī Putohū' lies in its depiction of rural life—how every member of a family contributes to earning a livelihood. But as soon as Anand's wife arrives as the new daughter-in-law, domestic harmony begins to break down. Sulekha comes from a prosperous family and fails to understand the difficulties faced by her mother-in-law Radha. Later, Radha's younger son Suresh marries and his educated wife Roshni enters the household; with her arrival the situation gradually becomes more orderly.

'Sāmpradāyik Sadbhāv' tells of the friendship between Rahman and Prakash, which creates a climate of harmony between two communities as the narrative progresses. Its simple and balanced treatment of a sensitive subject also permits it to be read as literature for children.

'Kanyāk Jingī' is the story of Kusum and the central character. After a long interval the protagonist returns to the village and meets a widow, who identifies herself as Kusum.

'Hṛday Parivartan' tells the story of a mother and son. After her husband's death, the mother goes to Patna with her son. Seeing the deep respect that former students retain for his father, the son regrets his own conduct.

'Gāmak Ektā' depicts the life of a village distressed by floods, incorporating the episode of Mala's childbirth. The entire village works together to reinforce a ring embankment and later takes Mala to hospital.

At certain points in these stories, opposition to marriages within the same caste is called regressive; in 'Navkī Putohū', although the two parties belong to the same caste, hatred is expressed towards inter-caste marriage. Nevertheless, Narayan Yadav's real strength is the subtle depiction of the life around him. The gentle presentation of communal harmony, collective life, and the unity of village and family obscures the other limitations.

5

A debate is under way over Sanju Das's paintings. Some consider them obscene, while others regard them as an expression of artistic freedom. Videha appeals for typed articles from both sides. The articles should be based on facts, not personal attachment or enmity. Articles may also be sent to editorial. staff. videha@gmail. com.

48. The Sahitya Akademi and Maithili Literary Organisations: A Discussion

Abstract

The Sahitya Akademi in Delhi, acting through an entirely secret process, removed two Maithili associations (the so-called Maithili literary associations in the Akademi's terminology) from its list and added three further non-literary associations. This is being seen as the beginning of the last rites—'Rām nām sat'—of the desiccating mainstream of Maithili literature. Of the previous list, recognition of associations numbered 1 and 6 was withdrawn, while entries numbered 5, 6, and 7 in the list below were added.

Keywords: Akademi · Literary · Organisation · Discussion · Literary · Current · Association

1

Maithili Literary Associations of the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi

Through an entirely secret procedure, the Sahitya Akademi removed two Maithili associations (the so-called Maithili literary associations, in the Akademi's terms) from its list and added three more non-literary

associations. This is being regarded as the commencement of the 'Rām nām sat'—the funeral chant—of the desiccating mainstream of Maithili literature.

Previous list:

1. The Secretary, All India Maithili Sahitya Samiti, Tirbhukti, 1/1B, Sir P. C. Banerjee Road, Allahabad-211 002;

2. The General Secretary, Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad, C/o Dr. Ganapati Mishra, Lalbag, Darbhanga-846 004;

3. The Secretary, Chetna Samity, Vidyapati Bhawan, Vidyapati Marg, Patna-800 001;

4. The Secretary, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, 6 B, Kailash Saha Lane, Kolkata-700 007;

5. The Secretary, Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Mithila Bhavan Parishar, Darbhanga-846 004;

6. The Secretary, Centre for the Study of Indian Traditions, Tantrabati Geeta Bhavan; Ranti House, Ranti, Madhubani-847 211

Of these, recognition of associations numbered 1 and 6 was withdrawn, while those numbered 5, 6, and 7 in the following list were added. Gain: 3 − 2 = 1. Loss: 'the beginning of the last rites of the desiccating mainstream of Maithili literature.'

(1) The General Secretary, Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad, Professors' Colony, Digahi West Opp. of Primary School, Darbhanga-846 004, (Bihar)

2) The Secretary, Chetna Samiti, Vidhya Pati Bhavan, Vidyapati Marg, Patna-800 001 (Bihar)

3) The Secretary, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, 6B, Kailash Saha Lane, Kolkata-700 007, (West Bengal)

4) The Secretary, Vidhya Pati Sewa Sansthan, Mithila Bhavan Parishar, Darbhanga-846 004, (Bihar)

5) The Secretary, Anand, Samajik Sanskritik Sahityik Manch, Rajkumarganj (Mirzapur Chowk), Darbhanga-846 004, (Bihar)

6) The General Secretary, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Roseberi 5032, Sahara Garden City, Adityapur-2 Jamshedpur-831 014, (Jharkhand)

7) The General Secretary, Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, G-6, Hans Bhavan, Wing 2 I. T. O., Bahadurshah Zafar Marg, New Delhi-110 002, (Delhi)

Now examine these bodies carefully. From the first to the last, they are connected with former chairs of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee. Whatever else they may be, they certainly are not literary associations. In Bengali there are still only two literary associations, but in Maithili every former chair of the Akademi's advisory committee went on declaring an organisation of his own so as to capture a position.

All this misconduct is being documented in my English book A Parallel History of Maithili Literature.

2

Introduction to the Commentary on Varṇa Prakaraṇa

At a seminar organised by Mailorang in Delhi, the late Mohan Bhardwaj once addressed a grammarian of the mainstream: 'Why is there not a grammar of Maithili? Are we not worthy of having a grammar of our own in Maithili?'

But the mainstream considers its duty discharged by patching together Hindi and Sanskrit grammars and making amendments such as 'the pronoun ham is plural in Hindi but singular in Maithili'. Against such patchwork grammar, Govindacharyaji of the parallel current produced an authentic grammar; his travels, like those of Pāṇini, made it possible.

In Sanskrit, for example, both the southern Indian word nīr and the northern Indian word jal are used for water. If, when teaching spoken Sanskrit, you teach a South Indian 'aham nīraṃ pibāmi' and a North Indian 'aham jalaṃ pibāmi', would you not be considered a good teacher?

Govindacharya—Pandit Bal Govind 'Arya', the noted Govind Yadav—has written Varṇa Prakaraṇa Bhāṣya-Bhūmikā (Maithili Grammar), which will also benefit schoolteachers.

3

Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal's novel Paṅgu received the Sahitya Akademi's principal award in 2021. The novel was published electronically in nine instalments in the Videha e-journal in 2018 and was subsequently collected in Videha-Sadeha 21. The book is now also available in the Videha archive.

49. Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

Abstract

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement. The Bride: Lalit Kumar's English translation of Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Maithili classic Kanyadan (Lalit Kumar, Assistant Professor, Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi), published by Harper Perennial, HarperCollins Publishers. The Bride: The Maithili Classic Kanyadan—an English translation of Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Kanyadan by Lalit Kumar (Assistant Professor, Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi); Harper Perennial (HarperCollins Publishers).

Keywords: Maithili · Parallel · Videha · Movement · Doing · Author's · Writing

Abstract

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement. The Bride: Lalit Kumar's English translation of the Maithili classic Kanyadan by Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), Assistant Professor, Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi; Harper Perennial, HarperCollins Publishers. The Bride: The Maithili Classic Kanyadan—an English translation of Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Kanyadan by Lalit Kumar (Assistant Professor, Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi); Harper Perennial (HarperCollins Publishers). The book was scheduled to reach my Kindle account on 1 December 2022, but the date was postponed, and it finally arrived in my account on 14 December 2022.

Editorial for the New Issue

1

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

The Bride: Lalit Kumar's English translation of Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Maithili classic Kanyadan (Assistant Professor, Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi), Harper Perennial, HarperCollins Publishers.

The Bride: The Maithili Classic Kanyadan—an English translation of Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Kanyadan by Lalit Kumar (Assistant Professor, Department of English, Deen Dayal Upadhyaya College, University of Delhi); Harper Perennial (HarperCollins Publishers).

I had preordered the book. It was scheduled to reach my Kindle account on 1 December 2022, but the delivery was postponed, and it finally reached my account on 14 December 2022.

I had already ordered the book. Its delivery to my Kindle account was scheduled for 1 December 2022, but delivery was delayed, and the book finally reached my account on 14 December 2022.

In 1965, when the Sahitya Akademi (India's national academy of letters) recognised Maithili, the late Ramanath Jha wrote that his Maithili language had now been saved (Ramanath Jha, "The Present Problem of Maithili").

When Maithili received recognition from the Sahitya Akademi (India's national academy of letters) in 1965, the late Ramanath Jha said that the Maithili language had now been saved (Ramanath Jha, "The Present Problem of Maithili").

Harish Trivedi has made a similar error. In his foreword, he writes that Maithili is the language closest to Hindi and was effectively an integral part of Hindi until it received constitutional recognition as a separate language in 1993. This statement is quoted in that form in the text under discussion.

Harish Trivedi has made the same mistake. In his introduction he writes: "Hindi, to which Maithili is closest (and of which it was virtually a part until its recognition as a separate language by the Constitution in 1993) ...."

Harish Trivedi refers to the inclusion of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution of India. The argument presented here is that the year should be 2003, not 1993. In my view, Maithili was a separate language in 2003, in 1993 and in 1965; it possessed an independent tradition even in the time of Vidyapati before Jyotirishwar. I argue further that certain conservative elements, including Ramanath Jha and Shardanand Jha, used the institutional recognition accorded by the Sahitya Akademi and the Constitution in their own way, to the detriment of Harimohan Jha's literary contribution. In my judgment, Khattar Kaka's Tarang, Pranamya Devata, Rangshala and Charchari were all worthy of the Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili from its inception in 1966. The essay sharply disagrees with the choice of a philosophical treatise for the 1966 award and records that no award was made for Maithili in 1967.

Harish Trivedi is referring to the inclusion of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution of India. Here the date should be 2003 rather than 1993. Moreover, Maithili was a distinct language in 2003, in 1993 and in 1965, and it was so even in the age of Vidyapati before Jyotirishwar. On the other hand, recognition by the Sahitya Akademi and the Constitution

strengthened the hands of Ramanath Jha, Shardanand Jha—whose names I mention here for particular reasons—and other conservative elements who continued to mislead and discourage Harimohan Jha. His Khattar Kaka's Tarang, Pranamya Devata, Rangshala and Charchari all deserved the Sahitya Akademi Award, which began for Maithili in 1966. Yet in 1966 the award went to a work of philosophy which, in my judgment, would oblige anyone who studied it to understand Indian philosophy to forget or discard a great deal before learning the subject afresh from a new book. No award was made for Maithili in 1967.

As an example of Ramanath Jha's conservative attitude towards the genealogical registers, I refer to the pañjī. Lalit Kumar, in my view, appears to have been influenced by the same tradition, even though he acknowledges other writers as the sources of his information. The essay alleges that Ramanath Jha knew of evidence of inter-caste marriages in the pañjī but did not make the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī public; it states that this register was published on Google Books in 2009. According to the account, the Navya-Nyāya philosopher Gangesha Upadhyaya married a woman described as a carmakāriṇī and was born five years after his father's death. The discussion refers to my Pañjī Prabandh, Volumes I and II, and to Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya's History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila.

Ramanath Jha's conservatism in relation to the pañjī becomes clear from an example. In my view, Lalit Kumar is following in his footsteps while attributing his own lack of knowledge to other authors. My charge is that Ramanath Jha was casteist, conservative and confused. He knew of inter-caste marriages recorded in the genealogical registers, yet kept the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī confidential. This register was made available on Google Books in 2009. According to my account, the great Navya-Nyāya philosopher Gangesha Upadhyaya married a carmakāriṇī, and he was born five years after the death of his father. See Panji Books, Volumes I–II, http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm. Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila:

The quoted statement makes a claim about the social standing of Gangesha's family and the disappearance of his lineage. I consider that claim entirely false. Bhattacharya states that he obtained this information from Professor R. Jha. On that basis, the essay criticises Ramanath Jha's outlook as casteist, conservative and confused, and rejects both the claim that recognition by the Sahitya Akademi "saved" Maithili and the notion that institutional recognition first established Maithili as a separate language.

"The family, regarded as low in social standing, has now disappeared from Mithila; Gangesha's family has been completely neglected, and we are not even expected to know his father's name." I regard this statement as

wholly false. Bhattacharya goes on to say that he received this information from Professor R. Jha. I ask: how could such a casteist, conservative and confused outlook have favoured an award for Harimohan Jha? Thus Professor R. Jha's assertion that recognition by the Sahitya Akademi saved the Maithili language is, in my judgment, wrong, as is Harish Trivedi's assertion.

In my view, the young translator Lalit Kumar has been influenced by conservative elements whose attitude does an injustice to Harimohan Jha's contribution. The essay states that, after recognition by the Sahitya Akademi, Harimohan Jha considerably reduced his writing in Maithili, and that in 1985, after his death, he received the Sahitya Akademi Award for his autobiography. I do not regard this belated honour as adequate.

Lalit Kumar is young, but in my view certain conservative elements are using him—the very elements who continued to mislead and discourage Harimohan Jha. Following recognition by the Sahitya Akademi, Harimohan Jha gave up writing in Maithili; in 1985, after his death, he received the Sahitya Akademi Award for his autobiography. I attach no particular significance to that belated honour.

Lalit Kumar writes that Yoganand Jha's Bhalmanush (1944) and Shardanand Jha's Jaybar (1946) attack the decisive social divisions governing marriage. I regard Bhalmanush as an epoch-making work but Jaybar as reactionary. In support of this judgment, the essay cites Radhakrishna Chaudhary's A Survey of Maithili Literature, which describes Bhalmanush as a novel concerned with the social problems of marriage and Jaybar as a second-rate response to it, of slight literary value.

Lalit Kumar writes: "Yoganand Jha's Bhalmanush (1944) and Shardanand Jha's Jaybar (1946) attack decisive social divisions within marriage." In my judgment, Yoganand Jha's Bhalmanush (1944) was certainly a pioneering novel, whereas Shardanand Jha's was reactionary. Professor Radhakrishna Chaudhary writes: "Yoganand Jha's Bhalmanush deals chiefly with the social problems connected with marriage. In reply to this novel, Shardanand Jha wrote a second-rate novel of little literary value entitled Jaybar." (Radhakrishna Chaudhary, A Survey of Maithili Literature.)

For his information concerning the pañjī, Lalit Kumar cites Mahamahopadhyaya Parmeshwar Jha's Mithila Tattva-Vimarsha. This essay cites Radhakrishna Chaudhary's assessment in A Survey of Maithili Literature: Mithila Tattva-Vimarsha is a history of Mithila in Maithili prose, based principally on tradition; Mukund Jha Bakshi's Mithilabhashamaya Itihas describes the dynasties of Mithila. Both are important to the development of modern Maithili prose, but Chaudhary considers them unreliable as historical accounts.

Lalit Kumar treats Mahamahopadhyaya Parmeshwar Jha's Mithila Tattva-Vimarsha as the source of his ignorance about the pañjī. Professor Radhakrishna Chaudhary writes: "Mahamahopadhyaya Parmeshwar Jha's Mithila Tattva-Vimarsha is a history of Mithila in Maithili prose, based chiefly upon tradition. Mahamahopadhyaya Mukund Jha Bakshi's Mithilabhashamaya Itihas gives an account of the dynasties. Both works are important from the standpoint of modern Maithili prose but are not reliable from the historical standpoint." (Radhakrishna Chaudhary, A Survey of Maithili Literature.)

For immediate reference, the following passage from my Pañjī Prabandh (Parts I and II) is reproduced:

For ready reference, I reproduce below the following passage from my Pañjī Prabandh (Parts I and II):

Maharaja Harisinghdev belonged to the Karnata dynasty of Mithila. In Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varṇa-Ratnākara, Harisinghdev was the patron or king. He was born in AD 1294 and ascended the throne in 1307. After his defeat by Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq in 1324–25, he fled to Nepal. He was the official founder of Mithila's pañjī system for Brahmins, Kayasthas and Kshatriyas. Gunakar Jha was initially appointed for the Maithil Brahmins, Shankardatta for the Karna Kayasthas, and Vijayadatta for the Kshatriyas. At Harisinghdev's instigation—Harisinghdev being a descendant of Nanyadeva, who had established the Karnata dynasty in Shaka 1009—"nandaida śūnyaṃ śaśi śāka varṣe" (Shaka 1019) ... the scholars of Mithila decided in Shaka 1248, corresponding to AD 1326, to inaugurate the present form of the pañjī system. Subsequently, a few intellectually self-indulgent men secured an order in AD 1760 from Maharaja Madhav Singh of Mithila to have the genealogists compile branch registers. After that, a new Brahmin sub-caste called Śrotriya emerged in Mithila within the pañjī system (sometimes dated to Shaka 1600, that is AD 1678, but in fact after Madhav Singh, around AD 1800).

On the basis of authentic pañjī records, this account concludes that the Śrotriya sub-caste emerged in approximately AD 1800.

The conclusion drawn from authentic pañjī records is that the Śrotriya sub-caste developed around AD 1800.

In his research, Anshuman Pandey writes that Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi provided him with digitised copies of the genealogical records of the Maithil Brahmins. Families of pañjīkāras have preserved these records from generation to generation and often regard them as intellectual property, limiting access by outside researchers. Pandey states that in 2007 he received the complete digitised collection of pañjī records from Gajendra Thakur. Reference: Anshuman Pandey, "Recasting the Brahmin

in Medieval Mithila: Origins of Caste Identity among the Maithil Brahmins of North Bihar," PhD dissertation, University of Michigan, 2014. According to this account, the pañjī manuscripts were later uploaded to Google Books in 2009.

Anshuman Pandey writes: "Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi provided me with digitised copies of the genealogical records of the Maithil Brahmins. Families of pañjīkāras who have preserved these records across generations are often reluctant to let others inspect them; for these families the records constitute a form of 'intellectual property'. I was fortunate to receive the complete digitised set of pañjī records from Gajendra Thakur in 2007." (Anshuman Pandey, Recasting the Brahmin in Medieval Mithila: Origins of Caste Identity among the Maithil Brahmins of North Bihar, PhD dissertation, University of Michigan, 2014.) The pañjī manuscripts were later uploaded to Google Books in 2009.

The essay states that the so-called Maharajas of Darbhanga were zamindars under Cornwallis's Permanent Settlement; there were numerous such landlords in British India but not in Nepal. The appendices to Pañjī Prabandh, Volumes I and II, are said to contain copies of orders of genealogically based elevation in social rank, which the author takes as evidence of advancement in exchange for money. On this basis I argue that before AD 1800 there was no separate Śrotriya sub-caste in British India and that none exists among the Maithil Brahmins of the Nepali part of Mithila even today. Formerly Śrotriya designated an adherent of a particular educational tradition, and, according to the author, the term is still used in that sense in Nepal.

In my view, the so-called Maharajas of Darbhanga were zamindars under Cornwallis's Permanent Settlement. There were many such landlords in British India, but none in Nepal. The appendices to Pañjī Prabandh, Volumes I–II, contain copies of orders of promotion in social rank based on genealogical registers—evidence, I argue, of elevation purchased for money. On this basis I conclude that before AD 1800 there was no sub-caste known as Śrotriya in British India; there is still no such sub-caste among the Maithil Brahmins in Nepal's Mithila. Earlier the term Śrotriya meant a follower of a particular educational tradition, and it continues to be used in that sense in Nepal.

In my judgment, Lalit Kumar attempts to establish a preconceived position by writing that "Harimohan chose a middle path in his reformist programme." He supports the claim by pointing to Harimohan's recognition of the importance of local traditions, language, script, educational practices and moral values. I find the argument absurd, since support for these things does not automatically make them conservative values.

Lalit Kumar writes further: "Harimohan chose a middle path in his reformist programme." In support he says that Harimohan "recognised the importance of local traditions, language, script, educational methods and moral values." I consider this argument ridiculous, because it implies that all these values are, by their very nature, conservative.

(All the books mentioned are available as free PDFs at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.)

(Free PDF editions of all the books mentioned are available at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.)

(To be continued.)

2

My Comments on Five Short-Short Stories by Acharya Ramanand Mandal

Five Short-Short Stories by Acharya Ramanand Mandal

Acharya Ramanand Mandal considers the following five short-short stories to be his finest:

Acharya Ramanand Mandal regards the following five short-short stories as his best:

1. Muṃhphaṭpan (Outspokenness)

2. Sharab ā Shabab (Liquor and Youthful Beauty)

3. Mahāyajña (The Great Sacrificial Rite)

4. Harbāh (The Ploughman), and

5. Jhapan (The Veil).

Acharya Ramanand Mandal is a retired headmaster and social thinker. He writes in the pure Maithili spoken in the Sitamarhi region.

Acharya Ramanand Mandal is a retired headmaster and social thinker. He writes in the pure Maithili spoken in Sitamarhi, the region associated with the birthplace of Goddess Sita.

The first story centres on a stern officer whose candour earns him both admiration and hatred. Precisely because he speaks plainly, he is falsely implicated. The vigilance department fabricates a case and has the witnesses sign the proceedings. When the case finally comes to a hearing almost ten years later, the witnesses withdraw their testimony. The officer is declared innocent, but his life has already been ruined. The story

comments not only on the working methods of law-enforcement institutions but also on the slowness of the judicial system.

The first story concerns a stern officer admired by some and hated by others for his frankness. Because of that very frankness, he is falsely implicated in a case. The vigilance department manufactures allegations and secures witnesses' signatures on the proceedings. Ten years later, when the case comes to trial, the witnesses retract their earlier statements. The officer is acquitted, but by then his life has been destroyed. This story is an indictment not only of the functioning of law-enforcement agencies but also of our sluggish judicial system.

The second short-short story depicts the moral decline of a bank employee who was initially both a good man and an accomplished mathematician.

The second story portrays the moral deterioration of a bank employee who, at the outset, is both a decent person and a skilled mathematician.

The third story takes the Gayatri Mahayajña as its setting. Questions of caste intervene, but the story discovers a ray of hope everywhere, and within every human being.

The third story centres on a Gayatri Mahayajña. Caste enters the narrative, yet the possibility of hope is found in every place and in every person.

Of the five, I regard the fourth story as the best. The author exposes how a system of bonded labour continued in the name of tradition. Towards the end, a new generation challenges that system. Education becomes an enabling factor, a force that makes change possible. According to the original commentary, this tradition had not previously been discussed in this manner in Maithili literature.

In my judgment, the fourth is the finest of the five stories. The writer reveals layer by layer how bonded labour was perpetuated under the name of tradition. Towards the conclusion, the younger generation challenges that tradition. Education becomes an instrument of change, and its significance is made clear. In my view, the subject had not previously received this kind of treatment in Maithili literature.

The fifth short-short story raises several issues, from mismatched marriages to the life of a widow. In my assessment it requires further refinement.

The fifth story raises many questions, ranging from unequal marriages to widowhood. In my opinion, the story needs revision.

Acharya Ramanand Mandal's strengths lie in his vocabulary and in his intimate knowledge of both the good and the harmful traditions of society. Greater prominence should be given to these strengths. Abrupt

endings do not leave readers wholly satisfied. I hope that, drawing on his gifts, he will reveal every aspect of his subject in its entirety; to do so, he must allow his characters sufficient time to develop.

Acharya Ramanand Mandal's great strength is his rich vocabulary and his deep familiarity with society's good and bad traditions. He should, I believe, place greater emphasis upon that strength. The sudden conclusion of a story does not fully satisfy the reader. He should use his strongest qualities to portray every dimension of his subject completely, and that will be possible only when the characters are given enough time to develop.

50. Maithili Literary Organisations, the Sahitya Akademi, and a Re-reading of Dhūrttasamāgama

Abstract

By granting recognition to seven non-literary Maithili associations, the Sahitya Akademi has done what is now becoming apparent: it has brought mainstream Maithili literature to ruin. Prem Mohan Mishra's advisory committee included, besides writers whom Videha had banned as alleged literary thieves, many other people of the same kind, who now serve on Ashok Avichal's advisory committee. Such people can easily be blackmailed because they have not reached these positions through merit.

Keywords: Literary · Organisation · Akademi · Re-reading of Dhūrttasamāgama · Asajjāti · Droṇa

Editorial for the New Issue

1

By recognising seven non-literary associations in Maithili, the Sahitya Akademi has done something whose consequences are now becoming evident: it has ruined mainstream Maithili literature. Prem Mohan Mishra's advisory committee included, apart from writers barred by Videha as alleged literary plagiarists, many other worthies who now sit on Ashok Avichal's advisory committee. Such people easily become victims of blackmail, for merit is not how they reach these positions. They are then handed assignments for seminars, translations, monographs and the like —works which, according to Amarji, nobody reads and which rot in the Sahitya Akademi's warehouses. In this way they make a little money and acquire an impressive curriculum vitae, from which, as Vidyanand Jha says, all manner of conclusions can be drawn, regardless of the quality of the work itself. Ashok Avichal and these seven non-literary associations have put forward a name: Dr Ajay Kumar Jha. He is the very mirror image of Ashok Avichal and the other mainstream writers. Yet mainstream circles have raised an outcry, saying that nobody knows him and that he is Ashok Avichal's sister's son. But those same people obtained translation assignments through influence, depriving writers of the parallel stream of their due, and Dr Ajay Kumar Jha has obtained an assignment in the very same manner. Ashok Avichal is from Rahua, and Dr Ajay Kumar Jha from Umri; whether they are uncle and nephew or related through maternal and paternal aunts is of little consequence to the parallel stream. I have already said that such people become vulnerable to blackmail, and Dr Ajay Kumar Jha's blackmail has now begun. He is making a list of the mainstream writers who abused him on social media and has begun

meeting them. If you read the story that follows, this may even seem appropriate: those writers will remain desperate for money, awards and fuller CVs, and they will leave you alone.

There was once a princess, the princess of an island of fairies, exceptionally capable and sharp-witted. A demon tormented the fairies of that island. They went to the princess and begged her to protect them. She said, "The next time the demon comes, send for me." When he came, the princess stood before him. Abandoning the other fairies, the demon pursued her. She led him to the southern part of the island, where gold lay everywhere. At the sight of it, the demon forgot the princess and began digging for gold. She returned and told the fairies, "You may now live without fear. Until his dying day he will go on digging for gold and will never trouble you again."

A play has also been written about the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee. Its name is Dhūrttasamāgama (The Assembly of Rogues). Jyotirishwar wrote it in the thirteenth century; he had an inkling of events that would unfold eight or nine hundred years later. That is why he is such a great dramatist! Read the following synopsis and identify its characters. If you recognise them, write to editorial.staff.videha@gmail.com. (Jyotirishwar has taken an author's liberty with the names of the places and characters.)

Dhūrttasamāgama was composed by Jyotirishwar Thakur in the thirteenth century and survives in Sanskrit and Maithili. Even the Sanskrit Dhūrttasamāgama includes songs in Maithili. The play belongs to the genre of prahasana, or farce. Most Maithili plays and dramatic pieces had drawn on the life of Krishna or his descendants, especially stories of abduction and svayaṃvara. Dhūrttasamāgama, however, has an ascetic and his disciple as its principal characters. Every character in it is a rogue of the first order; hence the title is entirely appropriate. Farce is also associated with music, so the inclusion of Maithili songs is wholly fitting. Its main characters are the Sūtradhāra, the Actress, the Graduate, Vishvanagar, Mritangara, Suratpriya, Anangasenā, Asajjāti Mishra, Bandhuvanchak, Mūlanāshak and the Citizen. The Sūtradhāra praises Narsinghdev, the jewel of the Karnata dynasty, and Jyotirishwar is then praised. The play contains a kind of absurdity that is strikingly modern; its flexibility makes it akin to folk theatre. Vishvanagar is celibate for want of a woman. Accompanied by his disciple, the Graduate, he goes begging to the house of Mritangara Thakur, where the household pleads ritual impurity. Vishvanagar then goes with his disciple to Suratpriya's house. Next, guru and disciple quarrel violently over a prostitute named Anangasenā. Together with Anangasenā they go to Asajjāti Mishra, a libertine who considers gambling and sexual intercourse the only two things of value in the world. Asajjāti Mishra asks,

"Who is the plaintiff, and who is the defendant?" The Graduate replies, "I am the plaintiff, for I must state the complaint; the ascetic is the defendant, since he must pay the fee." Vishvanagar offers the Graduate's bundle of cannabis as his fee. The jester whispers a description of Anangasenā's sexual attractions into Asajjāti Mishra's ear. Having placed Anangasenā between the two disputants, Asajjāti Mishra decides the case in his own favour. Meanwhile the jester whispers into Anangasenā's ear: "The ascetic is poor, the Graduate is a vagabond, and Mishra is a fool, so stay with me." Anangasenā looks in every direction and exclaims, "This has truly become an assembly of rogues!" Vishvanagar and the Graduate again set off towards Suratpriya's house. Meanwhile Mūlanāshak, the barber, demands a year's wages from Anangasenā. She sends him to Asajjāti Mishra. Mūlanāshak takes Asajjāti Mishra for Anangasenā's husband. Receiving cannabis as his fee, he lays Mishra down, ties him up and massages him so fiercely that Mishra loses consciousness. Believing him dead, the barber runs away. The jester arrives, unties Mishra and asks, "I have saved your life. Is there any other service you would like me to perform?" Asajjāti replies, "Through fraud I have consumed the whole country; through roguery I have won this beloved woman; and I have obtained an obedient disciple like you. Nothing more could please me. Nevertheless, I wish happiness and peace everywhere."

Like Jyotirishwar, I too have written about such shamelessness in my story "The Village of Mahisbar Brahmins": "For if you ask them the reason, they will tell you that these people are shameless, because at birth somebody spits on their backsides … so that not a trace of shame remains in any part of their bodies."

2

Three Droṇas, Including, for the First Time, a Woman Droṇa

The Sahitya Akademi's Maithili section appointed three Droṇācāryas to cut off Ekalavya's thumb. For the first time in world history, a woman Droṇa too was appointed to carry out this abhorrent task. All three discharged their duty with the dedication of executioners in Tihar Jail. An executioner is not to blame: the government pays him to carry out an execution. The fault lies with these Droṇas and with the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee, whose members are appointed through the seven so-called literary associations. Recognition of all seven associations should be withdrawn immediately. The Maithili section should operate like the English section, which has no literary association at all but functions perfectly well.

And do you not wish to know who these Droṇas are, and who Ekalavya is?

The Droṇas: Dr Devkant Jha, Dr Mantreshwar Jha and Dr Shefalika Verma.

Ekalavya: Rajdev Mandal.

The Droṇas may say that Rajdev Mandal's book never reached them, so how could they be blamed? Yet all three could have submitted a dissenting note; they could have refused. Moreover, they are symbols of the entire Maithili section of the Sahitya Akademi. A fuller response will appear in Videha's forthcoming special issue on literary corruption.

Videha invites contributions on the following subjects for its "Special Issue on Literary Corruption". Articles may be emailed to editorial.staff.videha@gmail.com.

1. Literature, the arts and government academies:

(a) Politics of awards;

(b) Undemocratic procedures for entering government academies;

(c) Power blocs and the functioning of academies;

(d) Working methods of parallel power structures that emerge from a merely ostensible opposition to state power;

(e) The role of money in academy awards: myth or reality.

2. Private literary institutions and the politics of awards.

3. Corruption in publishing and its effect on writers.

4. Spurious Maithili writers' organisations and the conduct of their office-bearers.

5. Forms of literary corruption in Maithili departments of schools and colleges:

(a) Curricula;

(b) Teaching and learning;

(c) Appointments.

6. Literary journalism, reviewing, the stage, garlands, microphones and the spectacle of book launches.

7. Selection of writers' birth and death centenaries, calendar-driven commemoration and the politics behind them.

8. Discrimination against, and various forms of exploitation of, Dalits and women writers.

9. Any other subject.

51. The Sahitya Akademi Translation Award (Maithili), 2022: A Literary Debate

Abstract

The question of the Sahitya Akademi Translation Award (Maithili), 2022. There were three jury members: Dr Savita Jha Soni, Dr Mitranath Jha and Mrs Nirja Renu. First let me tell you that the Sahitya Akademi assigns translation work only to Brahminists, depriving writers of the parallel stream of their rightful opportunities. Two members of the jury decided to award the prize to Ratneshwar Mishra; the third took offence.

Keywords: Akademi · Translation · Award · 2022 · Context · Literary · Debate

Editorial for the New Issue

1

The Sahitya Akademi Translation Award (Maithili), 2022

There were three jury members: Dr Savita Jha Soni, Dr Mitranath Jha and Mrs Nirja Renu. First I must tell you that the Sahitya Akademi gives translation assignments only to Brahminists, thereby depriving writers of the parallel stream of their due. Two jury members decided to confer the award upon Ratneshwar Mishra; the third became displeased. What was the need for this drama? Ratneshwar Mishra has no real connection with translation or literature. In his day he ran a successful coaching business in history, and his study notes sold well. He will not undertake another translation now; the purpose for which he did this one has been fulfilled. The Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee consists entirely of thieves and tricksters. The Akademi might as well declare thievery and trickery the minimum qualification for membership, since these are the very people who are admitted without any such declaration. We can expect nothing of them. But, sir, the prizewinner's shamelessness is extraordinary, and the speech he makes when accepting the award will be one to frame.

2

The 111th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray Held at Rahua Sangram

Dr Ashok Avichal, chair of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee, successfully organised the 111th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray in his personal capacity on Saturday, 31 December 2022, in the auditorium of Adinath Madhusudan Paras Mani Sanskrit College at Rahua Sangram. Thirty-three new stories were read, and Maithili fiction writers commented on them. Seventeen books in different genres were also

released. This gathering is held every three months, four times a year: in March, June, September and December.

Some mainstream writers informed me, on condition of anonymity, that Ashok Avichal and the seven non-literary associations had proposed Dr Ajay Kumar Jha for Sahitya Akademi membership. He is said to be Ashok Avichal's nephew (or, according to some, a relative through the maternal or paternal aunt's side). For that reason, mainstream fiction writers boycotted the 111th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray. When asked why Vibhuti Anand, Hirendra Kumar Jha, Daman Kumar Jha and Ashok Kumar Mehta nevertheless attended, the informants explained that the four had reached an agreement with Ashok Avichal: he would describe the event as the 112th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray. He did not do so in any invitation, however, and merely wrote the words "Sequence 112" in small letters at the top of the banner. At Hirendra Kumar Jha's instigation, therefore, Vibhuti Anand, who was presiding, together with Daman Kumar Jha and Ashok Kumar Mehta, ate and drank and departed after two or three hours. Writers of the parallel stream, by contrast, remained at the gathering until morning and made it a success. Let it be made clear that Hirendra Kumar Jha had done something similar before, as recorded in Videha: at the 89th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray, Auraha (Laukahi), 15 May 2013, convened by Umesh Paswan, he boycotted the gathering when it was not numbered 90, and Ashok Kumar Mehta also boycotted it at his instigation. Hirendra Kumar Jha is also adept at loose talk; if someone who has accompanied him wanders even slightly away, he pours out torrents of venom about that person. It should further be explained that, before writers of the parallel stream began attending Sagar Rati Deep Jaray, when Hirendra Kumar Jha and his circle dominated it, participants ate, drank and went to sleep, leaving the reader of a story awake alone. Ashish Anchinhar refused to read a story in protest, but this was omitted from the news issued by the mainstream the next morning. All this is documented in my book Prabandh–Nibandh–Samalochana, Part 2, available at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm. For the past ten years, the Sahitya Akademi has been trying to take over Sagar Rati Deep Jaray, the one forum of the parallel stream. It was unanimously decided that the 112th gathering would take place on the last Saturday of March 2023 at Sahuria (Andhratharhi), the ancestral village of Shri Ramchandra Ray, under his convenorship. Hirendra Kumar Jha continued what I call his blackmail with undiminished zeal when, on 2 January 2023, he telephoned Ramchandra Ray and made what I regard as a malicious Brahminist demand that the next gathering be numbered 113 rather than 112, even attempting to intimidate him, so that the Sahitya Akademi's event might somehow be recognised as a Sagar Rati Deep Jaray gathering. On 5 January 2023 he backed down. The Sahitya Akademi must be paying him for the work he has done towards this end for ten years; if it has not,

it will do so in future. Everything will be disclosed in Videha's forthcoming special issue on literary corruption.

It should be made clear in this connection that Ashok Avichal organised the gathering entirely in his personal capacity. Ten years ago, a Sahitya Akademi meeting in Delhi was held during the year marking Tagore's 150th birth anniversary. The Akademi described it as its own event in its annual report and financial accounts, recorded expenditure on it, and obtained the auditor's approval—expenditure that may properly have belonged under a programme devoted to Tagore, not under Sagar Rati Deep Jaray. For ten years, award- and assignment-hungry Brahminist members of the mainstream have striven to have that event recognised as part of Sagar Rati Deep Jaray. They have failed once again.

The following stories were read at the Rahua Sangram gathering: 1. Dr Vibhuti Anand, "Āsthā, Viśvās ā Paramparā" (Faith, Belief and Tradition); 2. Ravi Bhushan Kumar, "Bhojak Bahiṣkār" (Boycott of the Feast); 3. Manab Anish Mandal, "Satyak Bhrūṇ Hatyā" (The Killing of Truth in the Womb); 4. Ritik Mandal, "Gelaũ Ta Ham Gelaũ" (If I Went, Then I Went); 5. Pandit Shiv Kumar Mishra, "Vasudhā Kāhū Ko Na Hoy"; 6. Umesh Mandal, "Appan Jimmā" (One's Own Responsibility); 7. Acharya Ramanand Mandal, "Bāl Vairāgī" (The Child Ascetic); 8. Radhakant Mandal, "Bhumahur Āgi ā Alhuā"; 9. Jholi Paswan, "Kārī Nāg" (The Black Cobra); 10. Narayan Yadav, "Kaniyāk Jīvan" (The Bride's Life); 11. Kapileshwar Raut, "Chepharī"; 12. Jagdish Prasad Mandal, "Kumharak Batiyā" (The Potter's Words); 13. Amit Mishra, "Adhalāhak Pariṇām Adhalāhe" (Evil Begets Evil); 14. Baidyanathi Ram, "Hamhīṃ Dhanīk Chhī" (I Am the Wealthy One); 15. Harishchandra Jha, "Nirīkṣaṇ" (Inspection); 16. Pritam Kumar Nishad, "Buṛhārī Bhrūṇak Hatyā"; 17. Shravan Kumar Mandal, "Prem Vivāh" (Love Marriage); 18. Ramsevak Thakur, "Sāt Pūt Rāmkeṃ"; 19. Ramkrishna Pararthi, "Āṛi"; 20. Durgesh Mandal, "Dvandva" (Conflict); 21. Laldev Kamat, "Madhumāchhī" (The Honeybee); 22. Shardanand Singh, "Jāvat Soṅkhā Ke Nāv Hoyato Tāvat"; 23. Arvind Prasad, "Neṅgarū ā Maṅgarū"; 24. Ashok Avichal, "Manuā Nāchay Mor"; 25. Narayan Jha, "Rājnītimeṃ Rājnīti" (Politics within Politics); 26. Umesh Narayan Karna, "Māy" (Mother); 27. Durganand Mandal, "Sapnā" (Dream); 28. Ram Vilas Sahu, "Nīk Karab Ta Bejāe Kie Haet?" (Why Would Doing Good Be Wrong?); 29. Nand Vilas Ray, "Raṅgal Naṛhiyā"; 30. Ramchandra Ray, "Tohīṃ Jitaleṃ Hamhīṃ Hāralauṃ" (You Won; I Lost); 31. Rameshwar Prasad Mandal, "Hamaro Bahin Achhi" (I Too Have a Sister); 32. Vinay Mohan Jagdish, "Chhaṭṭhū"; and 33. Ramesh Kumar Sharma, "Saṅgharṣ" (Struggle).

The following books were released at the gathering: 1. Sāhityakārak Vivek (short-story collection), Jagdish Prasad Mandal; 2. Nab Banak Nab Phal (short-story

collection), Jagdish Prasad Mandal; 3. Suchitā (novel), Jagdish Prasad Mandal; 4. Pratikār Ekhan Bāṅkī Achhi (poetry collection), Ramkrishna Pararthi; 5. Asal Pūjā (short-story collection), Nand Vilas Ray; 6. Saṃyog (short-story collection), Rabindra Narayan Mishra; 7. Lajkoṭar (novel), Rabindra Narayan Mishra; 8. Ieh Thik Jīvan (memoir), Rabindra Narayan Mishra; 9. Rāṣṭra Mandir (novel), Rabindra Narayan Mishra; 10. Mātṛbhūmi (novel), Rabindra Narayan Mishra; 11. Sīmāk Ohi Pār (novel), Rabindra Narayan Mishra; 12. Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav, Gajendra Thakur; 13. Maithili Samīkṣāśāstra (criticism), Gajendra Thakur; 14. Rajdeo Mandal Maithili Writer, Gajendra Thakur; 15. Subhadra Kumari Chauhan (essay), Dr Ashok Avichal; 16. Jetae Ne Jāe Kavi Otae Jāe Anubhavī (collection of thought-provoking prose passages), Dr Umesh Mandal; 17. Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kāvya Saṅgrah (research analysis), Dr Umesh Mandal.

Subhash Chandra Yadav sent a message congratulating the parallel stream on the success of the ıı1th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray and expressing regret that he could not attend. The release of Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav aroused exceptional enthusiasm: those present repeatedly asked for copies, and orders began arriving by telephone from distant Delhi and other places on the very day of the launch.

The Storytelling Journey of Sagar Rati Deep Jaray, from the First to the ıı1th Gathering

1. Muzaffarpur — 21.01.1990; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.

2. Deorh — 29.04.1990; Jivakant.

3. Darbhanga — 07.07.1990; Dr Bhimnath Jha, Pradip Maithili Putra, Vijaykant Thakur.

4. Patna — 03.11.1990; Govind Jha, Damankant Jha.

5. Begusarai — 13.01.1991; Pradip Bihari.

6. Katihar — 22.04.1991; Ashok.

7. Nawani — 21.07.1991; Mohan Bharadwaj.

8. Sakri — 22.10.1991; Professor Sureshwar Jha, Dr Ram Babu.

9. Nehra — 11.10.1992; A. C. Deepak.

10. Biratnagar — 14.04.1992; Jitendra Jit.

11. Varanasi — 18.07.1992; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.

12. Patna — 19.10.1992; Rajmohan Jha.

13. Supaul–1 — 18.10.1993; Kedar Kanan.

14. Bokaro — 24.04.1993; Buddhinath Jha.

15. Paitghat — 10.07.1993; Dr Ramanand Jha ‘Raman’.

16. Janakpur — 09.10.1994; Ramesh Ranjan.
17. Isahpur — 06.02.1994; Dr Arvind Kumar ‘Akku’.
18. Sarhad — 23.04.1994; Amiya Kumar Jha.
19. Jhanjharpur — 09.07.1994; Shyamanand Chaudhary.
20. Ghoghardihā — 22.10.1994; Dr Narayanji.
21. Bahera — 21.01.1995; Kamlesh Jha.
22. Supaul (Darbhanga) — 08.04.1995; Kamlesh Jha.
23. Kathmandu — 23.09.1995; Dhirendra Premarshi.
24. Rajbiraj — 24.01.1996; Ramnarayan Dev.
25. Kolkata (Silver Jubilee) — 28.12.1996; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.
26. Mahishi — 13.04.1997; Dr Taranand Viyogi; sponsored by Ramesh.
27. Tarauni — 20.06.1997; Shobhakant.
28. Patna — 18.07.1997; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.
29. Begusarai — 13.09.1997; Pradip Bihari.
30. Khajauli — 04.04.1998; Pradip Bihari.
31. Saharsa — 18.07.1998; Ramesh.
32. Patna — 10.10.1998; Shyam Darihare.
33. Balain; Nagdah — 08.01.1999; Padam Sambhav.
34. Bhawanipur — 10.04.1999; Dr Jishnu Dutt Mishra.
35. Madhubani — 24.07.1999; Siyaram Jha ‘Saras’, Dr Kuldhari Singh.
36. Andauli — 20.10.1999; Kamlesh Jha.
37. Janakpur — 25.03.2000; Ramesh Ranjan.
38. Kathmandu — 25.06.2000; Dhirendra Premarshi.
39. Dhanbad — 21.10.2000; Shyam Darihare and Ramchandra Laldas.
40. Bittho — 21.01.2001; Dr Akku, Professor Vidyanand Jha.
41. Hatni (Ghoghardihā) — 19.05.2001; Professor Yoganand Jha / Ajit Kumar Azad.
42. Bokaro — 25.08.2001; Girijanand Jha ‘Ardhanarishwar’, Mithila Sahitya Parishad.
43. Patna (Kiran Jayanti) — 01.12.2001; Ashok, Chetna Samiti, Patna.
44. Ranchi — 13.04.2002; Kumar Manish Arvind.
45. Bhagalpur — 24.08.2002; Dhirendra Mohan Jha.
46. Patna (Vidyapati Bhavan) — 16.11.2002; Ajit Kumar Azad.
47. Kolkata — 22.01.2003; Karna Goshthi, Kolkata.
48. Khutauna — 07.06.2003; Dr Mahendra Narayan Ram.
49. Benipur — 20.09.2003; Kamlesh Jha.

50. Darbhanga — 21.02.2004; Dr Ashok Kumar Mehta.

51. Jamshedpur — 10.07.2004; Dr Ravindra Kumar Chaudhary.

52. Ranchi — 02.10.2004; Vivekanand Thakur.

53. Deoghar — 08.01.2005; Shyam Darihare and Avinash.

54. Begusarai — 09.04.2005; Pradip Bihari.

55. Purnia — 20.06.2005; Ramesh.

56. Patna — 03.11.2005; Ajit Kumar Azad.

57. Janakpur (Nepal) — 12.08.2006; Ramesh Ranjan.

58. Jaynagar — 02.12.2006; Narayan Yadav.

59. Begusarai — 10.02.2007; Pradip Bihari.

60. Saharsa — 21.07.2007; Kislay Krishna.

61. Supaul–2 — 01.12.2007; Arvind Thakur.

62. Jamshedpur — 03.05.2008; Dr Ravindra Kumar Chaudhary.

63. Ranchi — 19.07.2008; Kumar Manish Arvind.

64. Rahua Sangram (Madhubani) — 08.11.2008; Dr Ashok Avichal.

65. Patna (Katha Ganga–3) — 21.02.2009; Ajit Kumar Azad / Chetna Samiti.

66. Madhubani — 30.05.2009; Dilip Kumar Jha.

67. Samastipur — 05.09.2009; Ramakant Ray ‘Rama’.

68. Supaul–3 — 05.12.2009; Arvind Thakur.

69. Janakpur — 03.04.2010; Rajaram Singh ‘Rathore’.

70. Kabilpur (Darbhanga) — 12.06.2010; Dr Yoganand Jha.

71. Berma (Jhanjharpur) — 02.10.2010; Jagdish Prasad Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

72. Supaul — 04.12.2010; Arvind Thakur.

73. Mahishi (Katha Rajkamal) — 05.03.2011; Vijay Mahapatra.

74. Hazaribagh — 10.09.2011; Shyam Darihare.

75. Patna (Diamond Jubilee) — 10.12.2011; Ashok and Kamalmohan ‘Chunnu’.

76. Chennai — 14.07.2012; Vibha Rani.

77. Darbhanga (Kiran Jayanti) — 01.12.2012; Arvind Thakur.

78. Ghanshyampur — 09.03.2013; Kamlesh Jha.

79. Auraha (Laukahi) — 15.05.2013; Umesh Paswan.

80. Nirmali (Supaul) — 30.11.2013; Umesh Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

81. Deoghar (Bijli Kothi, Bampas Town) — 22.03.2014; Om Prakash Jha.

82. Mehath (Jhanjharpur; Katha Bauddha Siddha Mehathpa) — 31.05.2014; Gajendra Thakur.

83. Sakhua–Bhaptiahi — 30.08.2014; Nand Vilas Ray / Fagulal Sahu / Suraj Narayan Ray ‘Suman’.

84. Berma (Madhubani) — 20.12.2014; Shiv Kumar Mishra and local literature enthusiasts.

85. Bhagalpur (Shyam Kunj, Dwarikapuri) — 04.04.2015; Om Prakash Jha.

86. Laksena (Madhubani) — 20.06.2015; Rajdev Mandal ‘Raman’, Satyadev ‘Suman’.

87. Nirmali (Supaul) — 19.09.2015; Umesh Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

88. Dakhram Middle School (Benipur) — 30.01.2016; Kamlesh Jha, Amar Nath Jha.

89. Laukahi — 26.03.2016; Umesh Paswan and Prem Kumar Sahu.

90. Lakshminiya (Madhubani) — 18.06.2016; Ram Vilas Sahu and local literature enthusiasts.

91. Godhanpur (Madhubani) — 24.09.2016; Durganand Mandal.

92. Nawani (Madhubani) — 31.12.2016; Ajay Kumar Das ‘Pintu’.

93. Ratansara (Ghoghardihā) — 25.03.2017; Rajdev Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

94. Laufa (Madhepur) — 24.06.2017; Dr Yogendra Pathak Viyogi and local enthusiasts.

95. Jalsain Dumra (Madhubani) — 09.09.2017; Narayan Yadav.

96. Dhabouli (Laukahi) — 16.12.2017; Radhakant Mandal.

97. Berma (Lakhnaur) — 24.03.2018; Kapileshwar Raut and Berma villagers.

98. Simra (Jhanjharpur) — 16.06.2018; Dr Shiv Kumar Prasad.

99. Murhaddi (Barki Tol) — 22.09.2018; Professor Pritam Nishad.

100. Nirmali (Terapanth Bhavan) — 22.12.2018; Umesh Mandal, Navratna Vengani, Manish Jalan.

101. Jhitki (Madhubani) — 30.03.2019; Bharat Bhushan Jha.

102. Majhaura (Madhubani) — 29.06.2019; Jai Prakash Mandal, Alok Kumar.

103. Rampur (Madhubani) — 28.09.2019; Umesh Narayan Karna ‘Kalpa Kavi’.

104. Valam Nagar–Mahdeva (Laukahi) — 14.12.2019; Prem Kumar Sahu, Umesh Paswan.

105. Darbhanga (Sitayan Auditorium) — 13.02.2021; Kamlesh Jha.

106. Hatni (Ghoghardihā, Madhubani) — 25.09.2021; Laldev Kamat.

107. Belha (Phulparas; in memory of Jivakant) — 25.12.2021; Umesh Mandal, Engineer Shailendra Mandal.

108. Madhura (Madhubani) — 26.03.2022; Dr Shreeshankar Jha.

109. Nanaur (Madhubani) — 25.06.2022; Pradip Pushp.

110. Sonvarsha (Laukahi) — 24.09.2022; Achchhelal Shastri and local literature enthusiasts.

111. Rahua Sangram (Madhubani) — 31.12.2022.

The 112th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray will be held on the last Saturday of March 2023 in the ancestral village of Sahuria (Andhratharhi), under the convenorship of Shri Ramchandra Ray.

जय मैथिली.! जय साहित्य.!! आजुक जीवन आजुक साहित्य.!!!

हकार! हकार!! हकार!!!

भरि राति चलएबला मैथिली साहित्यक प्रसिद्ध
'सगर राति दीप जरय'क आगामी
आयोजन

कथा समन्वय

मे

अपने समस्त मैथिली साहित्य प्रेमीगणक उपस्थिति प्राथनीय अछि..

स्थान : आदिनाथ मधुसूदन पारस मणि संस्कृत महाविद्यालय, रहुआ संग्राम (मधुबनी)

दिनांक : 31 दिसम्बर 2022 (शनिदिन)

समय : 6 बजे साँझसँ 6 बजे भिनसर धरि

पोथी लोकार्पण

1.	साहित्यकारक विवेक (कथा संग्रह)	:	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
2.	नब बनक नब फल (कथा संग्रह)	:	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
3.	सुचिता (उपन्यास)	:	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
4.	प्रतिकार एखन बाँकी अछि (काव्य संग्रह)	:	रामकृष्ण परार्थी
5.	असल पूजा (कथा संग्रह)	:	नन्द विलास राय
6.	संयोग (कथा संग्रह)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
7.	लजकोटर (उपन्यास)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
8.	इएह थिक जीवन (संस्मरण)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
9.	राष्ट्र मंदिर (उपन्यास)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
10.	मातृभूमि (उपन्यास)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
11.	सीमाक ओहि पार (उपन्यास)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
12.	नित नवल सुभाष चन्द्र यादव	:	गजेन्द्र ठाकुर
13.	मैथिली समीक्षाशास्त्र (आलोचना)	:	गजेन्द्र ठाकुर
14.	Rajdeo Mandal Maithili Writer	:	Gajendra Thakur
15.	सुभद्रा कुमारी चौहान (विनिबन्ध)	:	अशोक अविचल
16.	जेतए ने जाए कवि ओतए जाए अनुभवी	:	उमेश मण्डल
17.	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डलक काव्य संग्रह	:	उमेश मण्डल

सम्पर्क-
विनयमोहन जगदीश, 9661406271
नारायण झा, 9534530451

निवेदक-
अशोक अविचल
9006056324

जय मैथिली.! जय साहित्य.!! आजुक जीवन आजुक साहित्य.!!!

हकार! हकार!! हकार!!!

भरि राति चलएबला मैथिली साहित्यक प्रसिद्ध
'सगर राति दीप जरय'क आगामी
आयोजन

कथा समन्वय

मे

अपने समस्त मैथिली साहित्य प्रेमीगणक उपस्थिति प्राथनीय अछि..

स्थान : आदिनाथ मधुसूदन पारस मणि संस्कृत महाविद्यालय, रहुआ संग्राम (मधुबनी)

दिनांक : 31 दिसम्बर 2022 (शनिदिन)

समय : 6 बजे साँझसँ 6 बजे भिनसर धरि

पोथी लोकार्पण

1.	साहित्यकारक विवेक (कथा संग्रह)	:	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
2.	नब बनक नब फल (कथा संग्रह)	:	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
3.	सुचिता (उपन्यास)	:	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
4.	हमर मीठ बैना (मुक्तक संग्रह)	:	नूतन झा
5.	असल पूजा (कथा संग्रह)	:	नन्द विलास राय
6.	प्रतिकार एखन बाँकी अछि (काव्य संग्रह)	:	रामकृष्ण परार्थी
7.	संयोग (कथा संग्रह)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
8.	इएह थिक जीवन (संस्मरण)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
9.	राष्ट्र मंदिर (उपन्यास)	:	रबीन्द्र नारायण मिश्र
10.	नित नवल सुभाष चन्द्र यादव	:	गजेन्द्र ठाकुर
11.	मैथिली समीक्षाशास्त्र (आलोचना)	:	गजेन्द्र ठाकुर
12.	Rajdeo Mandal Maithili Writer	:	Gajendra Thakur
13.	सुभद्रा कुमारी चौहान (विनिबन्ध)	:	अशोक अविचल
14.	जेतए ने जाए कवि ओतए जाए अनुभवी	:	उमेश मण्डल
15.	जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डलक काव्य संग्रह	:	उमेश मण्डल

सम्पर्क-
विनयमोहन जगदीश, 9661406271
नारायण झा, 9534530451

निवेदक-
अशोक अविचल
9006056324

जय मैथिली.! जय साहित्य.!! आजुक जीवन आजुक साहित्य.!!!

भरि राति चलएबला मैथिली साहित्यक प्रसिद्ध

सगर राति दीप जरय

केर

110म कथागोष्ठीमे

अपने समस्त मैथिली साहित्य प्रेमीगण सादर आमंत्रित छी

स्थान : मध्य विद्यालय, झहुरी मेला परिसर, सोनवर्षा (लौकही)

दिनांक : 24 सितम्बर 2022

समय : 6 बजे साँझसँ 6 बजे भिनसर धरि

कार्यक्रम : *दीप प्रज्ज्वलन, स्वागत, पोथी लोकार्पण, कथा पाठ, समीक्षा, आलोचना, धन्यवाद ज्ञापन, समापन, विदाइ... ।*

उद्घाटन :

श्री विनोद कुमार साह, अध्यक्ष, शिक्षा समिति, जिला परिषद्, मधुबनी

श्री रंधीर गोइत, पूर्व मुखिया, झहुरी पंचायत

श्री जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल, प्रसिद्ध साहित्यकार

डॉ. जय शंकर पाठक, प्रधानाचार्य, श्री युगेश्वर महन्थ पाठक संस्कृत महाविद्यालय , मंसापुर

पोथी लोकार्पण

1. जीवन दान (कथा संग्रह) : जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
2. अप्पन साती (कथा संग्रह) : जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डल
3. नढ़िया भुकैए हमर घराड़ीपर (गजल संग्रह) : जगदानन्द झा 'मनु'
4. पंगु (अनुदित उपन्यास) : रामेश्वर प्रसाद मण्डल
5. अभ्यन्तर (विचारोत्तेजक गद्यांश संकलन) : डॉ. उमेश मण्डल
6. जगदीश प्रसाद मण्डलक काव्य संसार (अनुसन्धान विश्लेषण) : डॉ. उमेश मण्डल

व्यवस्थापक-
समस्त ग्रामवासी
सोनवर्षा-धोबियाही

संयोजक-
अच्छेलाल शास्त्री
(कविजी)

3

On Kamalanand Jha

The title of Kamalanand Jha's book Maithili Novels: Time, Society and Questions (2021) is misleading. It is a compilation of supposedly critical essays, produced within a syndicate, on a handful of upper-caste novelists.

This 263-page hardbound volume can be sold only to libraries, where it will decay. I bought it from Amazon for four hundred and five rupees, but it contains not even five paise worth of material.

A correction is required here. Without having read Gulo, a novel by the non-upper-caste writer Subhash Chandra Yadav, he disposed of it in two lines. I reproduce those two lines for your amusement. You may already have read Gulo; if not, read it first, for the experience will then be still more entertaining. With Subhash Chandra Yadav's permission, Gulo is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

> "The weakness of the novel is the author's political prejudice. Partisanship towards a particular politics cannot do justice to a literary work."

In a novel in which politics is nowhere to be found, there can be no question of "political prejudice" or "partisanship towards a particular politics". Dhoomketu and Yatri employed the bogey of political prejudice and political allegiance. Subhash Chandra Yadav's Bhot, published in 2022 and also available with his permission in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm, does concern politics. Even there, however, the author's Bhagta style has no need of the bogey of political bias or partisanship. Read my book Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav, available at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

Kamalanand Jha's Brahminical caste prejudice against Subhash Chandra Yadav, expressed without reading the novel, is an alarm bell. The parallel stream is alert to the manner in which Kamalanand Jha, wearing the mask of the Left to advance Brahminism, wishes to sacrifice social justice. In his résumé he proudly records a Sahitya Akademi Maithili translation assignment obtained by taking away the rights of non-upper-caste and parallel-stream writers. It came to him not through merit but through his caste-marking surname and conduct of this kind. For people like him, Maithili is one line in a résumé; for the parallel stream, it is a question of life and death.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein is a historical autobiography of the Kosi River. He has written historical accounts of other rivers of Mithila as well: Bandini Mahananda; Bagmati Ki Sadgati!; Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein... (Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani); Na Ghat Na Ghar; Bagawat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi; Bhutahi Nadi Aur Takniki Jhaad-Phook; The Kamla River and People on Collision Course; Bhutahi Balan: Story of a Ghost River and Engineering Witchcraft; and Refugees of the Kosi Embankments. Pankaj Kumar Jha Parashar, a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee, translated this work paragraph by paragraph into Maithili and published it as a novel under his own name. A pseudo-critic calls this plagiarist's work "research"! That

research belongs to Dinesh Kumar Mishra. He earned a B.Tech. in civil engineering from IIT Kharagpur in 1968 and an M.Tech. in structural engineering in 1970; he is qualified for such research. When someone cannot obtain admission in the discipline of his choice, he sometimes settles, exhausted, for Hindi; otherwise Kamalanand Jha would have understood that this was the work of a civil engineer. Screenshots of the Hindi and Maithili texts are attached. Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not from Mithila, yet he has written the stories of its rivers. We are grateful to him: the people of Mithila can never repay the debt. The incident once again shows the ingratitude of mainstream writers greedy for awards and money. Ten or twelve years ago, this writer had found another rescuer in Taranand Viyogi, who explained that, under the influence of other works, he inadvertently brought other people's material into his own writing—or something of that kind. Now he has sought Kamalanand Jha's shelter, but to no avail.

All the books of Dinesh Kumar Mishra are now available in the Videha archive with his permission:

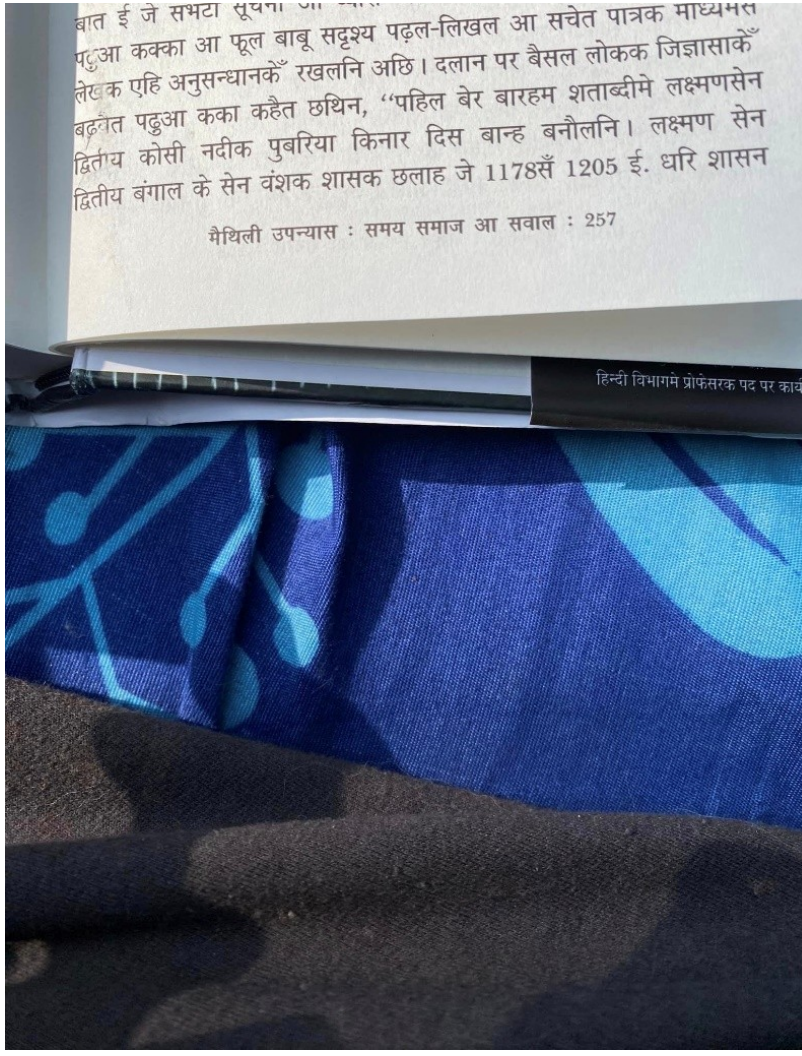
http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm

Let me recall something. When Bill Gates was asked whether Microsoft was delaying the launch of the Xbox in India because it feared piracy, he replied that Microsoft had never delayed any product for fear of piracy. Thus, despite the risks involved, we shall continue to enrich the Videha archive. In the parallel stream, a rotten fish does not make every fish in the pond rotten. The fisherfolk here have been removing the rotten fish one by one, and they will continue to do so.

To clear Kamalanand Jha's mind and vision, I recommend two books to him: first, Sushil's novel Gamwali (1982), and second, my Dooshan Panji: The Black Book. Both are available at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm. When my review of Sushil begins, I shall offer there a lesson intended for Kamalanand Jha.

I shall keep an eye on this pseudo-critic, Kamalanand Jha.

(To be continued in the next issue ...)


बात ई जे सभटा सूचना आ
पढुआ कक्का आ फूल बाबू सदृश्य पढ़ल-लिखल आ सचेत पात्रक माध्यमसँ
लेखक एहि अनुसन्धानकेँ रखलनि अछि। दलान पर बैसल लोकक जिज्ञासाकेँ
बढ़बैत पढुआ कका कहैत छथिन, "पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दीमे लक्ष्मणसेन
द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मण सेन
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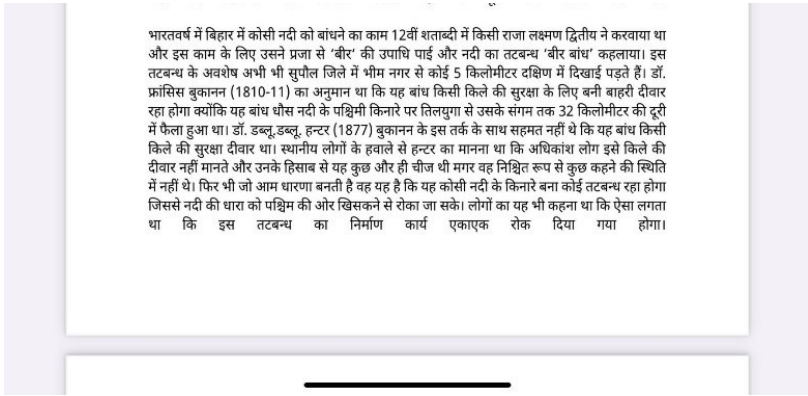
मैथिली उपन्यास : समय समाज आ सवाल : 257

हिन्दी विभागमे प्रोफेसरक पद पर कार्यरत

कयने छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगरसँ ८ कोस
पश्चिममे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकानन्क
अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह सम्भवतः कोनो किलाकेँ रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल
होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मतसँ डब्ल्यू. डब्ल्यू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलाह।
ओ साफ कहलनि जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल
होयत जे नदी पश्चिम दिस नहि बहय लागय।" एहि तरहेँ बान्हक महं
बहुत रास शेष अवशेष [illegible] अधिक ज्ञानात्मक उपयोग पराश्


भारतवर्ष में बिहार में कोसी नदी को बांधने का काम 12वीं शताब्दी में किसी राजा लक्ष्मण द्वितीय ने करवाया था और इस काम के लिए उसने प्रजा से 'बीर' की उपाधि पाई और नदी का तटबन्ध 'बीर बांध' कहलाया। इस तटबन्ध के अवशेष अभी भी सुपौल जिले में भीम नगर से कोई 5 किलोमीटर दक्षिण में दिखाई पड़ते हैं। डॉ. फ्रांसिस बुकानन (1810-11) का अनुमान था कि यह बांध किसी किले की सुरक्षा के लिए बनी बाहरी दीवार रहा होगा क्योंकि यह बांध घौस नदी के पश्चिमी किनारे पर तिलयुगा से उसके संगम तक 32 किलोमीटर की दूरी में फैला हुआ था। डॉ. डब्लू.डब्लू. हन्टर (1877) बुकानन के इस तर्क के साथ सहमत नहीं थे कि यह बांध किसी किले की सुरक्षा दीवार था। स्थानीय लोगों के हवाले से हन्टर का मानना था कि अधिकांश लोग इसे किले की दीवार नहीं मानते और उनके हिसाब से यह कुछ और ही चीज थी मगर वह निश्चित रूप से कुछ कहने की स्थिति में नहीं थे। फिर भी जो आम धारणा बनती है वह यह है कि यह कोसी नदी के किनारे बना कोई तटबन्ध रहा होगा जिससे नदी की धारा को पश्चिम की ओर खिसकने से रोका जा सके। लोगों का यह भी कहना था कि ऐसा लगता था कि इस तटबन्ध का निर्माण कार्य एकाएक रोक दिया गया होगा।

4

Just as Jyotirishwar treated this shamelessness in Dhurttasamagama, I too have discussed it in my story Mahisbar Brahmank Gam: "If you ask them the reason, they will say that all these people are shameless, because when they are born someone spits on their behinds … so that no shame remains anywhere in their bodies."

5

Videha invites articles for its "Special Issue on Literary Corruption" at editorial.staff.videha@gmail.com on the following subjects:
1. Literature, the arts and government academies:
(a) The politics of awards;
(b) Undemocratic procedures for entry into government academies;
(c) Power groups and the working methods of academies;
(d) The operations of temporary parallel power structures arising from a sham opposition to state power;
(e) The money factor in academy awards: myth or reality?
2. Private literary institutions and the politics of awards.
3. Corruption in the publishing world and its effects on writers.
4. Pseudo-organisations of Maithili writers and the conduct of their office-bearers.
5. Forms of literary corruption in Maithili departments of schools and colleges:
(a) Curricula;
(b) Teaching and learning;
(c) Appointments.
6. Literary journalism, reviews, public platforms, garlands, microphones and the theatrics of book launches.
7. The selection of birth and death centenaries of authors, calendar-centred commemorations and the politics behind them.
8. Discrimination against Dalits and women writers, and the various forms

of their exploitation.
9. Any other relevant subject.

—Gajendra Thakur, Editor, Videha; WhatsApp: +91 9560960721; http://videha.co.in/; ISSN 2229-547X.

6

You may now ask how the parallel stream responded. It does not indulge in whining. The answer lies in my three books released on 31 December 2022 at the 111th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray—the very gathering which, for the past ten years, the Sahitya Akademi has been trying to swallow up. I invite comments on all three books at editorial.staff.videha@gmail.com. The first two contain critiques of the literature of Rajdev Mandal and Subhash Chandra Yadav, undertaken according to the principles set out in my third book, Maithili Samikshashastra (Maithili Critical Theory).

Links to all three books are given below.

Rajdev Mandal—A Maithili Writer (now including Appendices I and II)

Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav

Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav (in Mithilakshar)

Maithili Critical Theory

Maithili Critical Theory (in Tirhuta)

Read also this attack on Kamalanand Jha's Brahminism:

Dooshan Panji: The Black Book

Dooshan Panji: The Black Book (in Mithilakshar)

7

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

Parallel Literature in Maithili and the Videha Maithili Literary Movement

Five Short-Short Stories by Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal

Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal regards the following five short-short stories as his best:

Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal considers the following five stories to be his finest:

Priya Kaj (Bhari Man Kaj)

Chali Gel Asha (Ayal Asha Chali Gel)

Jivandan (The Gift of Life)

On My Behalf (Appan Sati)

In "Sancharan", the philosophical reflections of Jibach Kaka on life are portrayed in all their richness, while the realities of the material world enter from time to time. There is detailed treatment of floods and embankments; the hopes of hydroelectric power raised by the Kosi River Project and the disappointment when those hopes went unfulfilled; irrigation facilities for farmers; the arrival of chemical fertilisers; the obstruction caused by the project to the natural flow of smaller rivers; memories of the village's old mango orchards; and rain-fed cultivation. After reaching the age of fifty, Jibach Kaka withdraws from household life in a spirit of detachment and entrusts responsibility to his two sons.

"Sancharan": Jibach Kaka's philosophical reflections on life appear in their full range, with material existence naturally entering at intervals. Floods and embankments; the hope of electricity from the Kosi River Project and the subsequent disappointment when it failed to materialise; irrigation for cultivators; the introduction of chemical fertilisers; the obstruction of smaller rivers by the project; memories of old village mango groves; and cultivation dependent on rainfall are all described in detail. After fifty, Jibach Kaka renounces the life of a householder and hands its responsibilities to his two sons.

"Bhari Man Kaj" is the story of Gyanchan. He is weighed down by the burdens of life, but Sumitlal tells him a story, and his heart grows lighter.

"Ayal Asha Chali Gel": The people of Rudrapur village are preparing for a pilgrimage to Rameswaram. A discussion takes place between Hiralal and Motilal.

"Jivan Dan": Sumant and his wife discuss life after the earthquake. All three houses had been destroyed in the earthquake the previous week.

"Appan Sati": At the centre of this story is the life of a village pulsing around the shops at a crossroads. The people, their priorities and their small disputes and altercations all come into view.

Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal is known for Maithili stories that relate the problems of the people of Mithila directly to their possible solutions. The solution is found among the people themselves, and the character who discovers it assumes the leading role in the story; such characters are always present. His fiction is known less for opposing migration than for

opposing the act of fleeing from life. Yet the five stories selected here are ones he regards as expressions of his philosophical thought. In them too, the priority is the people and their lives. Through Jibach Kaka the writer tells us that his life was magnificent. Magnificence does not lie in money but in the way life is lived. It is not shown through the life of a landlord but through that of ordinary people—those who suffer drought, floods and the adverse environmental consequences of new ideas of development, yet preserve their dignity.

Before and After the Arrival of Jagdish Prasad Mandal: The Landscape of Maithili Literature

Writing about the Bengal famine of 1942–43, Amartya Sen observes that millions died—approximately 1.5 million, according to the Famine Enquiry Commission—yet the tragedy did not reach his own loved ones. Likewise, Mithila suffered a devastating famine in 1967. When the then prime minister, Indira Gandhi, visited the region, she was shown members of the Musahar community surviving by eating *bisarah*: the roots of the lotus and other plants.

Yet it was not until 2009, more than forty years after the event, that Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal wrote about this tragedy. In the author's view, the reason for the delay is clear. A one-sided tendency had left the course of Maithili literature distorted and disfigured. Writers of the so-called mainstream had no direct experience of a calamity on this scale and were therefore unable to write about it.

The arrival of Jagdish Prasad Mandal on the literary scene was like the beginning of both a renaissance and a reform movement in Maithili literature. A brilliant new age began. In the author's view, Mandal deserves credit for dispelling the darkness, correcting the ugliness and one-sided direction of the literary landscape, filling its gaps, and straightening its crooked course.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal is an artist. He presents facts in such an extraordinary manner that the reader becomes wholly absorbed.

He possesses the capacity to give facts direction and purpose. Through this ability he has affected the definition and character of Maithili literature so profoundly that its history may be divided into two eras: before Jagdish Prasad Mandal and after Jagdish Prasad Mandal.

His facts are gathered from every stratum of society. They do not enter his prose as ornamental embellishments but emerge in its natural flow.

It seems as though a powerful tide has shaken the banks of the so-called principal channel of Maithili literature—a channel that dries up completely but regains its shape during the rainy season.

As though a great tide had unsettled the banks of the so-called mainstream channel of Maithili literature: a channel that almost dies in a drought, only to regain its form when the rains return.

His words do not lament. His writing does not retreat from responsibility. However many hardships his characters endure, they do not surrender hope, blame a lack of resources, or give themselves over to despair; they continue to advance with determination.

He respects the ways of life and contributions of every stratum of society—an exceptional quality. This is effective because there is no discrepancy between what he says and what he does; the dignity of his personal and social life lends his writing credibility. The concordance between what he thinks, what he does, and what he writes makes his literature truthful.

The rhythmic rises and falls of the Maithili language attracted even the great Yehudi Menuhin. In a BBC programme, he described it as one of the sweetest languages, saying that when he heard it his whole body swayed to its rhythm. Jagdish Prasad Mandal uses the inflections of this rhythmic language to express the interdependence of society and culture.

This change holds the possibility of a revolution not only in literature but also in the economic sphere.

SHAMBHUDAS

Jagdish Prasad Mandal plants an image of Barham Baba in the reader's mind. He shows that the devotees and Barham Baba himself are both pleased. He depicts the transformation of "Shambhua" (a disrespectful form of address) into "Shambhu" (a respectful form), and then shows Shambhudas becoming Darbaridas.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal establishes an image of "Barham Baba" in the reader's mind. He depicts both the devotees and Barham Baba as content. "Shambhua"—a contemptuous form of address—gradually becomes "Shambhu"—a respectful form; and then Shambhudas is seen turning into Darbaridas.

The collapse of Mithila's institutions and the reduction of Shambhudas to rubble are presented almost as evidence that cultivated arts are perishing in Mithila. Yet the protagonists of Mandal's other stories, such as *Bhaitak Lava* and *Bisrah*, do not collapse. Why, then, is Shambhudas becoming Darbaridas? Is this merely a loss of power, or is the writer Jagdish Prasad Mandal himself changing? Is he weary? Is he being defeated?

Viewed closely, Shambhudas is in no way inferior to the heroes and heroines of *Bhaitak Lava* or *Bisrah*. Why, then, is he losing? Should he not be victorious? Why does the writer push him towards defeat? Within

the world of his characters, the writer is like God; why, then, has he constructed circumstances in which Shambhudas finds himself losing?

Jagdish Prasad Mandal's characters are not artificial. For that very reason they do not invariably win on every economic front.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal's characters are not artificial; it is therefore not necessary that they should always prevail on every front of economic life.

On the economic front, work is accomplished by the hands and by labour. Culture, however—including literature—is like exceedingly delicate craftsmanship. The characters of this story become entangled in that intricate craft.

When Mandal's other characters found themselves compelled to fight on the economic front, they fought with their full strength and won. To serve art, however, Shambhudas had to leave—unlike the characters of *Bisrah*.

For this reason Shambhudas had to become a court artist. Economically, it was thankless work that offered no return; yet in changing times, surviving in that form seemed the only way to preserve the actual existence of art.

Even here, however, in a condition that may be considered defeat—and which was a defeat in economic terms—Shambhudas raises the flag of rebellion.

He decides not to marry, abandoning the possibility of family life. Shambhudas did not become Darbaridas merely to survive economically. He is no utilitarian; he had to compromise for the survival of art. His decision not to marry becomes a form of atonement for that compromise.

If art becomes "Darbaridas", the parallel tradition will collapse. Shambhudas's defeat would be Mithila's defeat; not only Jagdish Prasad Mandal but all Mithila would lose in that defeat.

BAJANTA-BUJHANTA

This is a collection of *bīj-kathā*, or seed-stories.

The title seed-story, "Bajanta-Bujhanta", concerns a parrot that is itself *bajanta-bujhanta*. Such symbolism is found more frequently in this collection of seed-stories than in the writer's other stories.

The title *vihani* story, "Bajanta-Bujhanta", concerns a parrot that is itself *bajanta-bujhanta*. This collection of *vihani* stories employs such symbols more extensively than the writer's other fiction.

In "Chaukidari", a working woman is seen labouring even in the eighth month of pregnancy, with a rope tied around her waist and abdomen.

The author dedicates "Patar" to Manoj Kumar Karna "Munnaji", a prominent practitioner of the *vihani* story, and offers a symbol: "Our condition is like a dark room, with snakes on all sides." The symbol carries the *vihani* story forward. A co-father-in-law says, "Well, you have even become someone who can understand the language of crows."

TAREGAN

This book contains neither complex plots nor difficult symbols, for it was written to instil good values in children.

There are few complex plots or convoluted symbols in this book, for the simple reason that its purpose is to cultivate good values among children.

Yet here the entire story itself becomes a symbol. When Subhas Chandra Bose's father tells him that merely sleeping on the ground is not enough, the words leave a deep impression upon his mind. What he subsequently did for India is well known. Satya Vidya Bharadwaj says, "Knowledge is greater than heaven."

The collection is important not only as children's literature; it also widens the horizons of the *vihani* story.

The poem "Chalu Uchitpur" imagines a place called Uchitpur, where everyone has the same body language and manner of dress. In that country there is no distinction between fire and water.

In the poem "Chalu Uchitpur", Uchitpur is a place where everyone's bodily gestures and clothing are alike. In that land there is not even any distinction between fire and water.

"A Full Moon Like a Moonless Night" says much about a distorted, "misshapen form".

"Yar Yau" is a song of tragedy. It describes all that the flood has carried away—not merely possessions, but morale and even the sense of one's own existence.

He dedicates the song to Shri Rajnandan Lal Das's "Yug-Yug", which depicts the condition of someone caught in a spider's web, with every door closed.

The song is dedicated to Shri Rajnandan Lal Das's "Yug-Yug", which portrays how every door closes upon a person trapped in a spider's web.

The entire collection of songs is dedicated to Professor Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa". Every song in the volume is rhythmic.

Baba failed to comprehend the malevolence of barren trees. He ploughed, hoed, and planted trees; later those very trees became abodes of departed

souls. They do not touch the earth but reach towards the sky by their topmost shoots.

Baba did not recognise the deception of the barren trees. He ploughed his field, prepared the soil, and planted the trees. Later those trees became dwelling places of the spirits of the dead, as though they no longer touched the ground but reached heaven by their uppermost tips.

"Haluk Kaj" describes the technical refinements of tools used in labour, which make the work easier. It also conveys the satisfaction an artist or craftsperson experiences when the work is done, while portraying how a world filled with sympathy comes into being.

Whether it is the syrup-like psychological plane of "Patta Chhimi" or an episode such as "The Tall Boy Is Guilty", the writer brings forward novel and distinctive forms of Maithili verse. This gives "Rait-Din" a different voice.

We hear someone singing a *nachari*, swaying body and voice in perfect rhythm; a *nachari* is a Maithili song associated with Lord Shiva. Both the spiritual and the supernatural find a place here. On one side is union or creation, on the other dissolution; change becomes a mere game.

We hear someone singing a *nachari*—a Maithili song to Lord Shiva—with body and voice moving together in full rhythm. There is room for both the spiritual and the supernatural. One force unites or creates, another disintegrates; change seems no more than a game.

The poet is exceedingly careful in choosing words and themes. Mystery, despondency, answers, questions, and hope repeatedly arrive and depart.

In "Ghare-Ghare", every house is bright with lamps, yet the entire village lies in darkness.

In "Ghare-Ghare", every house glows with a lamp, but the whole village is submerged in darkness.

"Kaushal-Jakhain" explains why the land became barren and how a village sunk in darkness came to such a pitiable condition.

SARITA

Here Jagdish Prasad Mandal's verse raises questions without cease—question after question.

Here the poetry of Jagdish Prasad Mandal continually raises questions; it goes on questioning.

His poetry expresses a painful awareness of fact and continues to ask questions until a conclusion is reached.

If we compare his poetry with his prose, we find more pessimism in the verse than in the hope-filled prose. The brevity of the poem does not afford him sufficient room to analyse a question at length and search for an answer. Consequently he keeps asking questions—questions that prod the reader to seek solutions independently.

Compared with his hopeful prose, his verse contains more pessimism. The shorter poetic form leaves little room to analyse questions and find answers. The poet therefore raises question after question, stirring readers to seek the solutions for themselves.

Such verse is an interesting and novel experiment in Maithili literature.

A Survey of Some Other Books by Jagdish Prasad Mandal

***Ulba Chaur*: collection of short stories, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2013.**

This collection contains thirteen short stories. Each portrays the vicissitudes of life, investigates the causes of problems, and offers solutions from a modern standpoint.

***Ardhangini*: collection of short stories, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2013.**

This collection contains twenty short stories. The writer vividly portrays the hardships of salaried people and contrasts them with the comparatively cheerful lives of cultivators. At the same time, he directly confronts the false beliefs prevalent among villagers and other social problems, proposing solutions. He also mentions traditional caste-based occupations and raises questions about their historical usefulness and necessity in the ordered life of the village.

***Satbhaiya Pokhair*: collection of short stories, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2013.**

Four editions of this book have been published so far.

***Bhakmor*: collection of short stories, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2013.**

The collection contains nine short stories. “Ojhari” and other stories, situated in the years following 1947, examine the erosion of democratic values and the deformation of public institutions.

***Nai Dharaiye*: novel, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2013.**

This novel is an attempt to discharge the obligation of literary creation, to which the writer has remained committed. Through a dynamic representation of life, it reflects the face of society.

***Krantiyog*: collection of short stories, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul, Bihar, 2017.**

The collection contains six stories. It effectively depicts how the building of highways, connecting roads, and houses raised on high foundations has aggravated drainage problems, damaged the environment, and intensified the resulting danger of floods. Ponds, wells, and orchards are diminishing in number and area; consequently thorny vegetation spreads and crops are damaged.

***Subhimani Jingi*: collection of short stories, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul, Bihar, 2018.**

The writer vividly depicts questions concerning the third gender. The adolescent Shyama is neither male nor female; therefore some people, including the mother, decide to hand the child over to the *kinnar* community. The father, however, stands by Shyama and resolves to impart all the skills needed for a life of dignity. He cites the example of Shiva as Ardhanarishvara, and of Krishna, who takes the form of Shivani and enters a group of women. Seeing the father's firm resolve, the mother also comes to support him.

The writer has addressed the question of the third gender, a subject rarely discussed in this way in Maithili literature. Shyama is, first of all, a child; this is beyond dispute. Shyama has a right to a dignified life and must be given the necessary skills. The brothers and sisters reason with their mother; after hearing the stories of Shiva and Krishna, she regrets that she was not taught them earlier. Especially in rural society, the life of third-gender people is presented from a new perspective. Other stories in the collection open up different social questions: "Babak Bag-Bagiya" examines monasteries and renunciation; "Kukurpan" considers village dispute resolution; and "Herayal Jingi", through the village of Kamalpur, proposes new approaches to development since independence, caste, and the defective model of development.

Subhimani Jingi ("A Dignified Life", 2018) is a collection of eight short stories. The second story, also entitled "Subhimani Jingi", gives the book its title. The book was written between 23 January and 9 March 2018 and published by Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali. Maithili has a quarterly, all-night short-story reading gathering, *Sagar Rati Deep Jaray*, held at

different locations. Its ninety-seventh gathering took place on 24 March 2018 in the village of Berma, under the convenorship of the writer Shri Kapileshwar Raut; this is also Jagdish Prasad Mandal's village. The book was launched on that occasion.

All eight stories vividly portray the continuing changes in the lives of village people.

The eight stories in the book are as follows:

1. "Kekra Lel Kelau": written on 23 January 2018.

2. "Subhimani Jingi": written on 28 January 2018.

3. "Babak Bag-Bagiya": written on 3 February 2018.

4. "Ab-Tab": written on 7 February 2018.

5. "Agilah": written on 11 February 2018.

6. "Kukurpan": written on 28 February 2018.

7. "Herayal Jingi": written on 5 March 2018.

8. "Asha Par Paani Phir Gel": written on 9 March 2018.

1. "Kekra Lel Kelau"

This short story begins with a conversation among people seated around a fire on a winter's day. Bhogilal Bhai is an Ayurvedic physician, yet he cannot keep himself in good health. His family, too, has come apart: apart from his wife, its members have migrated to the towns. The conversation ranges over the many changes in the village's natural and social environment—changes to which some people have been unable to adjust.

2. "Subhimani Jingi"

The writer addresses the question of the third gender, a topic rarely treated in this manner in Maithili literature. Shyama is, first and foremost, a child. Shyama has a right to a dignified life and should receive the skills needed to live it. The siblings reason with their mother. After hearing stories about Shiva and Krishna, she regrets that she had never previously been taught them. The story offers a new perspective on third-gender lives, particularly within rural society.

3. "Babak Bag-Bagiya"

This short story centres on the monastery and the question of renunciation. Govardhan Das was a poor child whose parents died during his childhood. He later succeeds Mahant Gokul Das. Through his story, the writer reaches deep into rural life, presenting aspects of village

existence seldom seen. Memories of Baba were bound up with the garden, but for want of proper care those gardens are now being destroyed.

4. "Ab-Tab"

Using the vegetables and ingredients served at village feasts, the writer raises questions about development's effects on rural life.

5. "Agilah"

Pakshadhar's uncle returns to the village after retirement. Munilal is a cousin or relative of his, and Munilal's daughter is a widow. Munilal and his daughter Savitri are the characters through whom Pakshadhar hopes to advance his programme of reform.

6. "Kukurpan"

The subject of "Kukurpan" is the method of resolving disputes in the village. A resolution is possible only through a person suited to that responsibility.

7. "Herayal Jingi"

Through the example of Kamalpur village, "Herayal Jingi" raises questions about rural development since independence, viewing caste and the defective development model from a new perspective.

8. "Asha Par Paani Phir Gel"

Lalit is an educated farmer. He begins cultivating sunflowers. Through Lalit's experiment, the writer finds scope to explore farmers' actual problems, natural calamities, and other practical difficulties.

***Dekhl Din*: collection of short stories, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul, Bihar, 2018.**

The title story compares a family that has lived in the village for three generations with another whose second generation migrated to the city, and establishes the superiority of the first family's way of life.

***Gapak Piyahul Lok*: collection of short stories, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul, Bihar, 2018.**

The collection contains thirteen short stories. The title story depicts a social structure carried forward from the Permanent Settlement and the age of landlordism. Resources were concentrated in the hands of a few, and in independent India the tendency continued in various forms. People began seizing land and litigation increased. The title story concerns such a

lawsuit involving Dinbandhu Kaka and thirty-five people; on the day judgment is to be delivered, a bus accident occurs.

***Lahsan*: novel, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul, Bihar, 2018.**

"Lahsan" tells the story of a rural man disillusioned with urban life, where social and personal morality seems meaningless. The novel vividly portrays village and city life; from the standpoint of ordinary people of the economically disadvantaged classes, urban life holds no particular attraction. The plot revolves around personal turmoil, but the novel's real strength lies in its extensive portrayal of town and village through the eyes of those on the lower rungs of the economic order.

***Rahe Joker Pariwar*: collection of short stories, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul, Bihar, 2020.**

Loss of livelihood is a principal reason for migration from Mithila. Migrants, however, also include prosperous people seeking an easier life. Nearly thirty years earlier, Shantinath, though well-off, left Chainpur for "Shanti Niketan" in search of peace. The villagers subsequently met him, but he expressed no regret. Unlike the writer's other books, this work uses the migration of materially comfortable people in search of peace to compare and depict the inner contradictions of Mithila's social life.

***Gamak Jingi*: collection of short stories, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2009.**

This short-story collection contains nineteen stories. The writer received the Tagore Literary Award (Sahitya Akademi) for this book. Each story portrays the harshness of rural life. People must bend before natural calamities, yet the characters repeatedly rise again, refusing either to surrender or to migrate.

***Maulayal Gachhak Phool*: novel, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2009.**

This is the writer's first novel and centres on the problem of migration from villages. The novelist imagines revitalising a decaying system so that migration may be stopped.

***Utthan-Patan*: novel, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2009.**

Even a profoundly indolent person may make progress if he desires economic advancement. Shyamanand introduces technology into agriculture. To prevent the fragmentation of the village and migration, unity is essential; the narrative stresses this proposition.

***Jingik Jeet*: novel, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2009.**

Many works centred on village life give undue prominence to negative forces. The writer seeks to bring an end to the despair produced by such negative portrayals.

***Mithilak Beti*: play, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2009.**

This play raises questions about the pitiable lives of daughters in Mithila's villages. Discrimination takes many forms; the writer selects the distorted relationships a woman may encounter after marriage. Their fundamental cause is shown to lie in the unequal treatment accorded to sons and daughters from the day of birth.

***Taregan*: collection of inspirational stories, Shruti Publication, New Delhi, 2010.**

This is a book of children's literature containing 111 inspirational seed-stories; it also incorporates the essential substance of some outstanding works of world literature selected for young readers.

***Jeevan-Maran*: novel, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2010.**

The writer's spiritual perspective comes to the foreground in this work; the meaning of earthly existence is viewed from the perspective of the afterlife.

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***Jeevan Sangharsh*: novel, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2010.**

The writer compares two villages, Banspura and Sisauni. In his account, Banspura is less developed and Sisauni relatively more developed; this conception of development emerges both from the villagers' experience and from the writer's perspective. Sisauni has a middle school and holds public Durga worship and a fair; Banspura has none of these facilities, although a privately organised twenty-four-hour *kirtan* and occasional communal feasts take place there. Barharba is depicted as more developed than either: it has a high school and more public events. The discussion then turns to Katharba, which has not only a high school but also a hospital and organises numerous public programmes.

***Bajanta-Bujhanta*: collection of seed-stories, Shruti Publication, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi, 2013.**

This collection contains sixty-eight seed-stories woven around various social questions. The principal concerns are the changes and upheavals taking place at both personal and social levels within villages.

Pseudo-Criticism in Maithili and the Question of Kamalanand Jha

Kamalanand Jha's Brahminical caste prejudice against Subhash Chandra Yadav, expressed without reading his work, is an alarm bell. The parallel stream is alert to the manner in which Kamalanand Jha clings to the pretence of the Left in order to advance Brahminism, and seeks to sacrifice social justice in the process. In his biographical note he proudly mentions a Sahitya Akademi Maithili translation assignment obtained, I maintain, by taking away the rights of a non-upper-caste writer and of people in the parallel stream. The assignment, I contend, came to him not through merit but through his caste title and such activities. For people like him, Maithili is a line on a curriculum vitae; for the parallel stream, it is a question of life and death.

Why have I called Kamalanand Jha a pseudo-critic? Because he is one. He writes: "Almost a hundred years after the Maithili novel began its journey, the credit for writing a dignified novel on the dreams, struggles and ironies of inter-caste marriage among Maithils goes to Gaurinath." Has Kamalanand Jha therefore deprived Sushil of this credit? Is this the height of the arrogance of his Brahminical upbringing—the belief that "I can elevate whom I wish and bring down whom I wish"—or evidence of his lack of study? Come, let me take you away from Kamalanand Jha's self-interested world, away from deceit and pretence, into the innocent, magical literary world of Sushil. Welcome to Sushil's literary world. Here is his *Gamwali* (1982), now available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm. Before the novel itself begins, Sushil writes on its very first line: "In support of widow remarriage and inter-caste marriage." Then the novel begins. Gamwali dies, and a dispute immediately arises: who will perform her funeral rites—the Brahmin community or the Yadav community?

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's *Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein* is a historical autobiography of the Kosi River. He has also written historical autobiographies of other rivers of Mithila: *Bandini Mahananda*; *Bagmati Ki Sadgati!*; *Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein... (Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani)*; *Na Ghat Na Ghar*; *Bagavat Par Majbur Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi*; *Bhutahi Nadi Aur Takniki Jhar-Phunk*; *The Kamla River and People on Collision Course*; *Bhutahi Balan: Story of a Ghost River and Engineering Witchcraft*; and *Refugees of the Kosi Embankments*. Pankaj Jha Parashar, a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board, translated these books into Maithili paragraph by paragraph and published a novel in his own name; the pseudo-critic Kamalanand Jha calls this plagiarising novelist's work "research"! Let me make clear that both this plagiarising novelist and this pseudo-critic work in the Hindi Department of Aligarh Muslim University. This research belongs to Dinesh Kumar Mishra, who

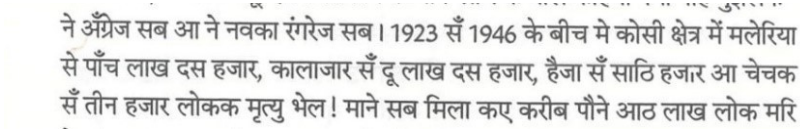
obtained his B.Tech. in Civil Engineering from IIT Kharagpur in 1968 and his M.Tech. in Structural Engineering in 1970, and is qualified to undertake it. When people fail to gain admission to any subject, they eventually enrol in Hindi in resignation; otherwise Kamalanand Jha would understand that such research could be the work of a civil engineer—perhaps he understands it already. Screenshots of the Hindi original and the Maithili text are appended below.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not from Mithila, yet he has written the stories of all its rivers. We are grateful to him, and the people of Mithila can never fully repay their debt to him. The award- and money-hungry people of the mainstream, however, will repay gratitude with ingratitude: this has been demonstrated again. Some ten or twelve years ago, this same writer was defended by Taranand Viyogi, who wrote something to the effect that, influenced by poetry, he unconsciously borrowed material from another person's work. Now he has sought Kamalanand Jha's protection, but to his misfortune! The parallel stream is vigilant against Kamalanand Jha's practice of sheltering under the Left while seeking to advance Brahminism and sacrifice social justice. Landowners became communists to escape land-ceiling laws; now others seek refuge in the Left to protect Brahminism. People of this kind have greatly damaged communism.

All of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's books are now available in the Videha archive with his permission:
http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm
Let me recall something here. When Bill Gates was asked whether he was delaying the Xbox's launch in India out of fear of piracy, he replied that Microsoft had never postponed a product because of piracy. Thus, despite such risks, we shall continue enriching the Videha collection. In the parallel stream, a rotten fish does not cause every fish in the pond to rot: the fisherfolk here have removed rotten fish one by one and will continue to do so.

The Final Assault on Syndicated Criticism

Original passage by Dinesh Kumar Mishra (*Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein…*, 2006): “It is worth noting that between 1923 and 1946, the Kosi region recorded 510,000 deaths from malaria, 210,000 from kala-azar, 60,000 from cholera, and 3,000 from smallpox—a total of 783,000 deaths.”
The plagiarist Pankaj Jha Parashar (member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board), *Jalprantar* (2017), p. 103:

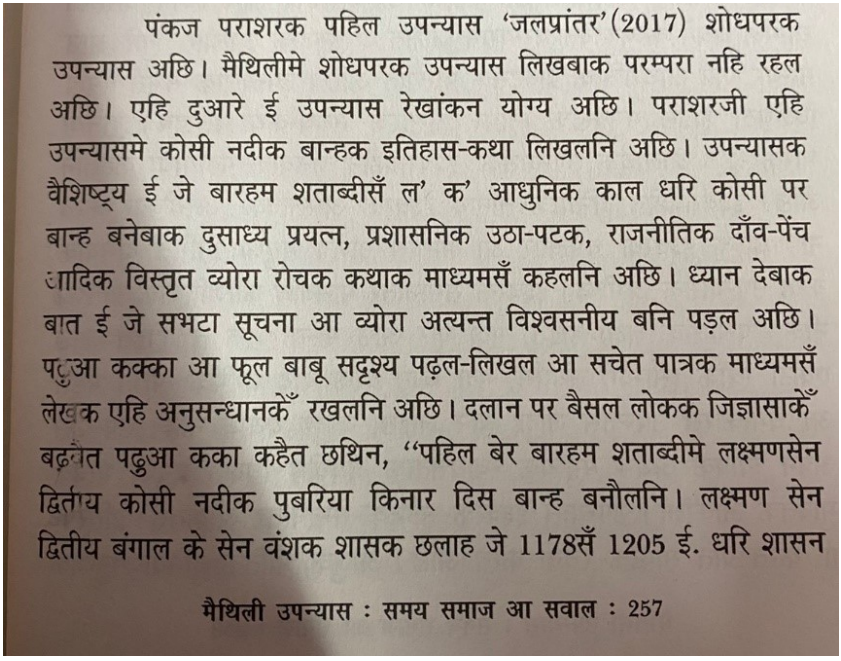

ने अँग्रेज सब आ ने नवका रंगरेज सब। 1923 सँ 1946 के बीच मे कोसी क्षेत्र में मलेरिया
से पाँच लाख दस हजार, कालाजार सँ दू लाख दस हजार, हैजा सँ साठि हजार आ चेचक
सँ तीन हजार लोकक मृत्यु भेल! माने सब मिला कए करीब पौने आठ लाख लोक मरि

English translation of reproduced extract:

“Between 1923 and 1946, 510,000 people died of malaria in the Kosi region, 210,000 of kala-azar, 60,000 of cholera, and 3,000 of smallpox. Taken together, nearly 775,000 people died.”

Original passage by Dinesh Kumar Mishra (*Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein…*, 2006): “In India, the work of embanking the Kosi River in Bihar was undertaken in the twelfth century by a certain King Lakshman II. For this work his subjects conferred on him the title ‘Bir’, and the river embankment became known as the ‘Bir Bandh’. Remains of this embankment can still be seen about five kilometres south of Bhim Nagar in Supaul district. Dr Francis Buchanan (1810–11) conjectured that the embankment had been an outer wall built to protect a fort, since it extended for thirty-two kilometres along the western bank of the Dhaus River, as far as its confluence with the Tilyuga. Dr W. W. Hunter (1877) disagreed with Buchanan's argument that the embankment was a fortification wall. Reporting local opinion, Hunter said that most people did not regard it as the wall of a fort; they considered it something else, although he was not in a position to say precisely what. Nevertheless, the general impression is that it was an embankment along the Kosi River designed to prevent the river's course from shifting westward. People also said that the construction of this embankment appeared to have been halted abruptly.”

The pseudo-critic Kamalanand Jha praises the plagiarising novelist. See the passage by Pankaj Jha Parashar quoted by Kamalanand Jha in *Maithili Upanyas, Samay, Samaj Aa Sawal*, pp. 257–58:

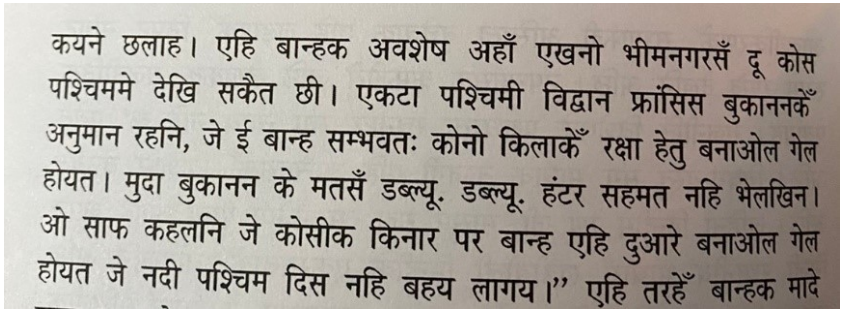


पंकज पराशरक पहिल उपन्यास 'जलप्रांतर'(2017) शोधपरक उपन्यास अछि। मैथिलीमे शोधपरक उपन्यास लिखबाक परम्परा नहि रहल अछि। एहि दुआरे ई उपन्यास रेखांकन योग्य अछि। पराशरजी एहि उपन्यासमे कोसी नदीक बान्हक इतिहास-कथा लिखलनि अछि। उपन्यासक वैशिष्ट्य ई जे बारहम शताब्दीसँ ल' क' आधुनिक काल धरि कोसी पर बान्ह बनेबाक दुसाध्य प्रयत्न, प्रशासनिक उठा-पटक, राजनीतिक दाँव-पेंच आदिक विस्तृत व्योरा रोचक कथाक माध्यमसँ कहलनि अछि। ध्यान देबाक बात ई जे सभटा सूचना आ व्योरा अत्यन्त विश्वसनीय बनि पड़ल अछि। पढुआ कक्का आ फूल बाबू सदृश्य पढ़ल-लिखल आ सचेत पात्रक माध्यमसँ लेखक एहि अनुसन्धानकेँ रखलनि अछि। दलान पर बैसल लोकक जिज्ञासाकेँ बढ़बैत पढुआ कका कहैत छथिन, "पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दीमे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मण सेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह जे 1178सँ 1205 ई. धरि शासन

मैथिली उपन्यास : समय समाज आ सवाल : 257

English translation of reproduced extract:

"Pankaj Parashar's first novel, *Jalprantar* (2017), is a research-based novel. There has been no tradition of writing research-based novels in Maithili; for that reason this novel deserves particular attention. In it Parashar tells the history of the embankments along the Kosi River. The novel's special feature is that it presents, through an engaging narrative, detailed accounts of the arduous efforts to build embankments on the Kosi from the twelfth century to modern times, administrative upheavals, political manoeuvring, and much else. What should be noted is that the entire body of information and detail appears extremely credible. Through educated and perceptive characters such as Parhua Kaka and Phool Babu, the writer has incorporated this research into the work. As the people seated in the courtyard become increasingly curious, Parhua Kaka says: 'For the first time, in the twelfth century, Lakshman Sen II built an embankment along the eastern bank of the Kosi. Lakshman Sen II was a ruler of Bengal's Sena dynasty, who ruled from AD 1178 to 1205…'"


कयने छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगरसँ दू कोस पश्चिममे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकाननकेँ अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह सम्भवतः कोनो किलाकेँ रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मतसँ डब्ल्यू. डब्ल्यू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलनि जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत जे नदी पश्चिम दिस नहि बहय लागय।" एहि तरहेँ बान्हक मादे

English translation of reproduced extract:

"'…He ruled during those years. You can still see the remains of this embankment about two *kos* west of Bhimnagar. A Western scholar, Francis Buchanan, supposed that it may have been built to protect a fort. But W. W. Hunter did not agree with Buchanan. He said plainly that the embankment along the Kosi was probably built to keep the river from flowing westward.' In this way the account continues…"

The plagiarist Pankaj Jha Parashar (member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board), *Jalprantar* (2017), p. 31:

पढ़ुआ कका पछिला गप कें आगाँ बढ़बैत कहलखिन, 'फूल बाबू, कोसी नदीक बेसिन प्राचीन काल सँ मनुक्खक निवास लेल उपयुक्त स्थान रहल अछि। बारहम-तेरहम सदी मे भारत मे जखन कइक टा नदी सुखा गेल, तँ ओहि ठामक पशुचारक समाजक लोक एतय आबि कए बसलाह। तहिये सँ बढ़ैत जनसंख्या आ कोसी नदीक बदलैत प्रवाहक मध्य टकराहटि होमय लागल। नदीक अनियंत्रित धारा कें लोक बाढ़ि बूझय लागल। पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दी मे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह, जे 1178 सँ 1205 ईस्वी धरि शासन कयनें छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगर सँ दू कोस पश्चिम मे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकानन के अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह संभवत: कोनो किला के रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मत सँ डब्लू. डब्लू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलखिन, जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत, जे नदी पच्छिम दिस नहि बह' लागय।' पढ़ुआ कका सँ मुँहजबानी एतेक रास ऐतिहासिक तथ्य सुनियो कए फूल बाबू सहमति मे मूड़ी नहि डोलेलखिन। जाहि सँ ओतय बैसल लोक सबहक उत्सुकता और बढ़ि गेलनि, जे गप मे एहेन कोन तथ्य रहि गेलै जे फूल बाबू संतुष्ट नहि भेलखिन ? लोक कें बुझेलनि जे फूल बाबू शास्त्रार्थ के अखड़हा पर माटि फेकि रहल छथिन। पढ़ुआ कका कें आइ जोड़ीदार भेटि गेलनि!

जलप्रांतर / 31

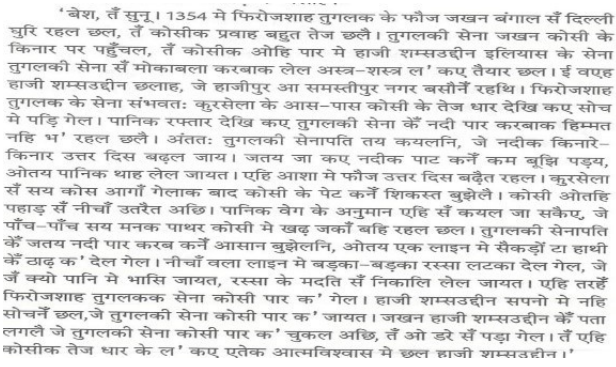
English translation of reproduced extract:

"Padua Kaka takes the matter further, saying: 'Phool Babu, in ancient times there were suitable places for human settlement along the Kosi River. In the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, as many rivers in India dried up, many pastoral people began to migrate. With the growing population, people came into conflict with the changing course of the Kosi. The uncontrolled current began to submerge people. It was in the twelfth century that Lakshman Sen II first built an embankment along the Kosi's eastern bank. Lakshman Sen II was a ruler of Bengal's Sena dynasty and ruled from 1178 to 1205. Remains of the embankment can still be seen about two *kos* west of Bhimnagar. A Western scholar, Francis Buchanan, conjectured that this embankment may have been constructed to protect a fort. But W. W. Hunter did not agree with Buchanan. He stated plainly that the embankment must have been made along the Kosi so that the river would not flow westward.' Hearing Padua Kaka, I found a great many historical facts, but I could not entirely agree with Phool Babu. The people there grew more curious about matters not found in the village;

why did Phool Babu not seem satisfied? People forgot that Phool Babu had flung aside the newspaper in anger. Padua Kaka was making his point forcefully!"

Original passage by Dinesh Kumar Mishra (*Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein…*, 2006): "A glimpse of the terrifying force of the Kosi's current is found in the account of Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army returning to Delhi from Bengal in 1354. It is said that when the Sultan's troops reached the bank of the Kosi, they saw the army of Haji Shamsuddin Ilyas drawn up for battle on the opposite bank. This was the Haji Shamsuddin who founded the towns of Hajipur and Samastipur. Firoz's soldiers appear to have stood perplexed on the bank of the Kosi somewhere near Kursela. The river's speed prevented them from moving forward. It was eventually decided to proceed northwards along the river and test the depth of the water wherever a crossing appeared possible. The Sultan's army went nearly a hundred *kos* upstream and crossed the river near Jiyaran, at the point where the river descended from the mountains into the plains. Although the channel was narrower there, the current was so strong that heavy stones weighing five hundred *man* apiece were carried along like straws. At the place where a crossing seemed possible, the Sultan arranged rows of elephants on both sides, with ropes hanging down from the downstream row so that anyone swept away might be rescued by grasping them. Shamsuddin had never imagined the Sultan's forces would cross the Kosi. When he learnt that they had succeeded, he fled."

The plagiarist Pankaj Jha Parashar (member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board), *Jalprantar* (2017), p. 105:



'बेश, तँ सुनू। 1354 मे फिरोजशाह तुगलक के फौज जखन बंगाल सँ दिल्ली घुरि रहल छल, तँ कोसीक प्रवाह बहुत तेज छलै। तुगलकी सेना जखन कोसी के किनार पर पहुँचल, तँ कोसीक ओहि पार मे हाजी शम्सउद्दीन इलियास के सेना तुगलकी सेना सँ मोकाबला करबाक लेल अस्त्र–शस्त्र ल' कए तैयार छल। ई वएह हाजी शम्सउद्दीन छलाह, जे हाजीपुर आ समस्तीपुर नगर बसौने रहथि। फिरोजशाह तुगलक के सेना संभवतः कुरसेला के आस–पास कोसी के तेज धार देखि कए सोच मे पड़ि गेल। पानिक रफ्तार देखि कए तुगलकी सेना कें नदी पार करबाक हिम्मत नहि भ' रहल छलै। अंततः तुगलकी सेनापति तय कयलनि, जे नदीक किनारे–किनार उत्तर दिस बढ़ल जाय। जतय जा कए नदीक पाट कनें कम बूझि पड़य, ओतय पानिक थाह लेल जायत। एहि आशा मे फौज उत्तर दिस बढ़ैत रहल। कुरसेला सँ सय कोस आगाँ गेलाक बाद कोसी के पेट कनें शिकस्त बुझेलै। कोसी ओतहि पहाड़ सँ नीचाँ उतरैत अछि। पानिक वेग के अनुमान एहि सँ कयल जा सकैए, जे पाँच–पाँच सय मनक पाथर कोसी मे खढ़ जकाँ बहि रहल छल। तुगलकी सेनापति कें जतय नदी पार करब कनें आसान बुझेलनि, ओतय एक लाइन मे सैकड़ों टा हाथी कें ठाढ़ क' देल गेल। नीचाँ वला लाइन मे बड़का–बड़का रस्सा लटका देल गेल, जे जँ क्यो पानि मे भासि जायत, रस्सा के मदति सँ निकालि लेल जायत। एहि तरहें फिरोजशाह तुगलकक सेना कोसी पार क' गेल। हाजी शम्सउद्दीन सपनो मे नहि सोचनें छल,जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' जायत। जखन हाजी शम्सउद्दीन कें पता लगलै जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' चुकल अछि, तँ ओ डरे सँ पड़ा गेल। तँ एहि कोसीक तेज धार के ल' कए एतेक आत्मविश्वास मे छल हाजी शम्सउद्दीन।'

English translation of reproduced extract:

"'Very well, listen. In 1354, when Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army was returning from Bengal to Delhi, it encountered the frightening force of the Kosi. On reaching the riverbank, the soldiers found Haji Shamsuddin Ilyas's army standing ready to fight on the far side. He was the Haji Shamsuddin who established Hajipur and

Samastipur. Firoz Shah's army stood bewildered somewhere near Kursela, for the Kosi's current prevented them from advancing. They decided to march north along the river and look for a place where they might cross. After proceeding roughly a hundred *kos*, they reached Jiyaran, near the point where the river leaves the mountains for the plains. The channel was narrower, but the current was so fierce that stones weighing five hundred *man* were swept away like blades of grass. To enable a crossing, the Sultan stationed lines of elephants on both sides and hung ropes from the downstream line so that anyone swept away might be rescued. Haji Shamsuddin had never imagined that the Sultan's army could cross the Kosi; when he learned that it had crossed, he fled.'"

52. The Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee (2023–2028): A Discussion

Abstract

Of the ten members of the renowned Maithili Advisory Committee of the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi (2023–2028), six are Brahmins and one is a neo-Brahminist. Not a single non-upper-caste writer from the parallel literary stream has been included, although these writers have devoted their lives to Maithili for the past fifteen years despite limited financial resources. Nachiketa Ji's advisory committee is an elite body. It will work for the elites among both forward and backward communities; those who are marginalised within literature will remain marginalised, and those who have kept Rajdev Mandal Ji's writings at bay will continue to do so.

Keywords: Akademi · advisory · committee · 2023 · 2028 · discussion · women

Abstract

Of the ten members of the renowned Maithili Advisory Committee of the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi (2023–2028), six are Brahmins and one is a neo-Brahminist. Not a single non-upper-caste writer from the parallel stream has been included, although such writers have devoted their lives to Maithili for the past fifteen years despite limited financial resources. Nachiketa Ji's advisory committee is an elite body. It will work for elites among both forward and backward communities; those who are marginalised within literature will remain marginalised, and those who have kept Rajdev Mandal Ji's writings at bay will continue doing so. This is an alarm bell for the writers of the parallel stream: they will have to work at twice their previous pace.

I

Of the ten members of the renowned Maithili Advisory Committee of the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi (2023–2028), six are Brahmins and one is a neo-Brahminist. Not a single non-upper-caste writer from the parallel stream has been included, although such writers have devoted their lives to Maithili for the past fifteen years despite limited financial resources. Nachiketa Ji's advisory committee is an elite body. It will work for elites among both forward and backward communities; those who are marginalised within literature will remain marginalised, and those who have kept Rajdev Mandal Ji's writings at bay will continue doing so. This is an alarm bell for the writers of the parallel stream: they will have to work at twice their previous pace.

List: Ushakiran Khan, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Pramod Kumar Jha, Devshankar Naveen, Taranand Viyogi, Vidyanand Jha, Raman Kumar Singh, Ajay Jha, Veena Thakur, Nachiketa.

2

The Appreciation and Criticism of Art: Theoretical Considerations

1

The Dancing Girl (!) or the Figure of a Woman (2500 BCE)

The earliest works of art found in India are the objects recovered from the Indus Valley civilisation.

The so-called Dancing Girl (!) or figure of a woman, cast in bronze, was found at Mohenjo-daro. The artist is unknown, but the work represents the artistic accomplishment of Mohenjo-daro at its finest. Roughly four inches high, two inches wide and one inch thick, it is now housed in the Indus Valley Civilisation Gallery of the National Museum, New Delhi.

(Courtesy: Joe Ravi, Wikimedia, CC BY-SA 3.0)

To appreciate this work of art, let us now consider what qualities make it outstanding.

1. It represents a slender, thinly built woman.

2. The woman is standing, her left hand on her left thigh and her right hand at her waist, towards the back.

3. Her eyes are large.

4. Her hair is curly.

5. Her nose is flattened.

6. The woman is nude; only a necklace around her neck and bangles on her arms are visible. She has twenty-four bangles on her left arm but only four on her right.

7. Her combed hair is tied in a bun at the back.

8. Her head is tilted backwards.

9. Her arms appear comparatively long.

This is a representation of a woman: why, then, has it been called a dancing girl? Do you find even a single feature in it identifying the woman as a dancer? The National Museum and history books describe it as a dancing girl. This, I contend, is a consequence of a male-centred mentality, in which even a woman writer such as Romila Thapar—who is a historian rather than an art historian—has become entangled. Such misunderstandings arise despite the study of art history and archaeology.

2

The Dark-Complexioned Princess in the Frescoes of Ajanta (200 BCE–480 CE)

A mural in one of the Ajanta caves—among the oldest examples of painting—portrays an exceptionally beautiful, dark-complexioned princess wearing ornaments, including ornaments in her hair.

3

Khajuraho (950–1050 CE)

[Khārjura (scorpion, Sanskrit vṛścika): an apsarā reveals her thigh, upon which a scorpion is depicted; the name Khajuraho is said here to derive from this.]

Romila Thapar describes the artwork here as escapist art. Even Jayadeva's thirteenth-century Gīta Govinda appears new to Romila. Art historians and archaeologists disagree with her view. The art historian Devangana

Desai argues that the yoni and liṅga were present in non-Aryan civilisations, while Vātsyāyana's Kāmasūtra and Kālidāsa's Kumārasambhava long predate Khajuraho and the Gīta Govinda. She explains that the scorpion is compared to the poison of sexual craving, and that this is the conception represented on the apsarā's thigh.

53. The Mithila Student Union Special Issue: Organisation, Movement and Criticism

Abstract

Despite the so-called literary figures and so-called literary associations of Maithili and Mithila—armed, as it were, with eighty hands apiece and supported by the Sahitya Akademi—and despite the self-proclaimed Mithila leaders and organisations claiming international stature, we decided to publish a special issue devoted to the Mithila Student Union. Our purpose was to identify the difference between activities undertaken merely to create a record and work that genuinely constitutes action. The chief activity of the allegedly caste-bound organisations of Mithila and Maithili, including caste-bound Maithili theatre organisations, is to place garlands around people, publish magazines and commemorative volumes, and conduct similar exercises that merely build a record. Such activities carry no importance in Videha's view.

Keywords: Mithila · Student · Union · special issue · organisation · movement · criticism

Abstract

Despite the so-called literary figures and so-called literary associations of Maithili and Mithila—armed, as it were, with eighty hands apiece and supported by the Sahitya Akademi—and despite the self-proclaimed Mithila leaders and organisations claiming international stature, we decided to publish a special issue devoted to the Mithila Student Union. Our purpose was to identify the difference between activities undertaken merely to create a record and work that genuinely constitutes action. The chief activity of the allegedly caste-bound organisations of Mithila and Maithili, including caste-bound Maithili theatre organisations, is to place garlands around people, publish magazines and commemorative volumes, and conduct similar exercises that merely build a record. Such activities carry no importance in Videha's view. You may add "international" or even "universal" to your organisation's name; that will make no difference to Videha.

Editorial

Despite the so-called literary figures and so-called literary associations of Maithili and Mithila—armed, as it were, with eighty hands apiece and supported by the Sahitya Akademi—and despite the self-proclaimed Mithila leaders and organisations claiming international stature, we decided to publish a special issue devoted to the Mithila Student Union. Our purpose was to identify the difference between activities undertaken merely to create a record and work that genuinely constitutes action. The

chief activity of the allegedly caste-bound organisations of Mithila and Maithili, including caste-bound Maithili theatre organisations, is to place garlands around people, publish magazines and commemorative volumes, and conduct similar exercises that merely build a record. Such activities carry no importance in Videha's view. You may add "international" or even "universal" to your organisation's name; that will make no difference to Videha, since these organisations are increasing caste-based rigidity: they are pocket organisations.

A special issue of Videha is not a commemorative volume of praise. Many contributions to the Mithila Student Union special issue also contain numerous criticisms of the Union. Perhaps the organisation (MSU) will make some improvements in light of these criticisms, for it is an organisation, not a pocket organisation; of that there is no doubt.

Language Technology and Modern Communication

54. Language and Technology (Computers, Photography, Keyboards and Typing Techniques), Maithili on the Internet, Writing on the World Wide Web and E-Publishing

Abstract

Google and WordPress offer many ready-made templates for creating blogs, along with apparently unlimited data storage for writing, messages and comments and free web hosting. These blog-building services are user-centred and provide facilities for straightforward writing. But if you wish to construct and manage a website based on Structured Query Language (SQL), this essay will be useful to you.

Keywords: language · technology · computer · photography · keyboard · typing · techniques

Google and WordPress offer many ready-made templates for creating blogs, along with apparently unlimited data storage for writing, messages and comments and free web hosting. These blog-building services are user-centred and provide facilities for straightforward writing. But if you wish to construct and manage a website based on Structured Query Language (SQL), this essay will be useful to you. First I shall explain the procedure for writing Mithilakshar and Devanagari in Unicode and discuss how such writing can be made readable on the internet. Thereafter I shall discuss in detail the methods of constructing websites.

How to Type Devanagari Using a Roman Keyboard

First go to www.bhashaindia.com and download Hindi IME Version 5. Install the program on your computer. Then open Control Panel and select Regional and Language Options; click the Languages tab. Check whether "Install files for complex script and right-to-left languages" has been selected. If not, select it and follow the computer's instructions. Then go again to the Languages tab and click Details. Click Add, choose Hindi as the language and HINDI INDIC IME 1 [V.5.1] as the keyboard, and select Apply. Restart the computer. Now open a Word document. Press the left Alt and Shift keys together; an H will appear as the keyboard indicator. Alternatively, click the language indicator below and select Hindi. The available keyboard choices include Hindi transliteration, Remington, InScript and other layouts. Select a layout and begin typing.

With the transliteration keyboard, to type राम you must type "raama". To produce क्, with its halant, press "k" and click the left mouse button; otherwise, pressing the space bar or Enter will cause the halant to disappear.

Wikipedia had an article about Maithili but no articles written in Maithili, since a Maithili Wikipedia had not yet received approval. I had been working on this for a long time, and permission to begin a wiki in the Maithili language was obtained on 27 October 2008. I had translated many English computer terms during the localisation of terminology, and this increased both my interest and my involvement in the work.

Another software tool for typing in Devanagari is available at http://www.baraha.com/BarahaIME.htm. Its distinctive feature is a Sanskrit keyboard, something not available in other software tools. It provides udātta, anudātta, svarita and certain other Sanskrit characters, although it does not provide such forms as svastika, gvāṅ and añjī. After typing स, the forms सं, सॅ, से and सऽ can be made by pressing Shift with 3, 2, 4 and 7 respectively.

To write the Tirhuta script, visit the following link:

http://www.tirhutalipi.4t.com/

For this, however, download and copy the Preeti font available through that link and place both items in C:/Windows/Fonts on the hard-disk drive. The font used here is ASCII-based. Kruti Dev and Shusha are of the same kind. They were useful earlier, but search engines now search Unicode UTF-8 text, and Devanagari written using ASCII fonts cannot be found by such searches. Windows includes the Mangal typeface, which uses Unicode, and Devanagari written with it can be searched. An application for the Unicode encoding of Mithilakshar, submitted by Anshuman

Pandey, is pending. I too contributed to it at the request of Professor Deborah Anderson of the University of California, Berkeley, Project Leader of the Script Encoding Initiative in the Department of Linguistics, UC Berkeley.

Now a few points about Unicode and websites.

To read a file, the required font must be installed on the computer. Otherwise, the simplest solution is to convert an article written in a word processor—a Word document—into a PDF file. This has both advantages and disadvantages. The advantage is that the PDF can be read in whatever typeface or script it has been written, without the problem of installing fonts. The disadvantage is that if you select "Save as Text", the English will be saved, but the Devanagari may be saved in a form that cannot be read. Another problem sometimes arises when a document typed in the Unicode Mangal font is converted into PDF using Adobe Acrobat: घ with a halant and sometimes ज appear as unreadable rectangular boxes. In that case, open the entire file, select everything, choose "Universal Unicode MS" from the font drop-down menu, and then select Adobe Acrobat as the printer under Print. The file will then be converted into PDF.

A direct method of converting Microsoft Word to PDF is to choose File and then Print, select Acrobat Distiller as the printer and issue the print command. Sometimes, however, no PDF document is produced. In that case, select Acrobat Distiller, open Properties, and select Adobe PDF Settings. There you will find the option "Do not send fonts to Distiller" checked; uncheck it. Exit the settings and issue the print command. A PDF document will now be created. With PDF splitting and merging software—for example, the freeware PDF Helper or SAM—you can easily join and divide PDF files.

Before constructing a website, consider a few essential matters. There are five kinds of internet browsers, on which the others are based. First install all five on your computer:

1. Opera; 2. Mozilla; 3. Microsoft's Internet Explorer (which will already be there); 4. Google Chrome; and 5. Apple's Safari (formerly available only for Macintosh, but now also for Windows). Whenever you upload a webpage —or even before uploading it—make sure to open and examine it in all these browsers.

Baraha IME has made a distinctive contribution to Devanagari typing. It enables the writing of Sanskrit udātta, anudātta and svarita accents, modifications, Devanagari numerals and some musical notation. It includes notation for the lower octave, and for sharp and flat notes (*tīvra* and *komal*). The vowels ऋ, ॠ, ऌ, ॡ, ऍ and ऎ, as well as joining after अ and the sign ~ with a halant, are available. Anudātta क̱, udātta क॑ and

svarita के are also provided. It works with Windows Vista and, because it uses Unicode fonts, the result is readable on the internet.

The alphabet runs from अ to ह. Although क्ष, त्र and ज्ञ are conjunct letters, from childhood we have been taught the alphabet as extending from अ to ज्ञ. श्र, too, is a conjunct like क्ष, त्र and ज्ञ. For this reason we pronounce ज्ञ as though it were a combination of ग and य, but that is wrong: it is a combination of ज and ञ. We pronounce ऋ as "ri", and we pronounce ऌ as a combination of ल, र and ई. Yet ऋ and ऌ are independent vowels, not conjunct letters. The Videha archive provides the pronunciation of every letter from अ to ज्ञ in recognition of the need for accurate pronunciation. The use of the international form of Indian numerals has become customary in Devanagari. Article 343(1) of the Indian Constitution stipulates that the form of numerals used for the official purposes of the Union shall be the international form of Indian numerals. The President, however, may also authorise the Devanagari form of numerals.

Download the TBIL Converter from http://www.bhashaindia.com. To convert from another font to Mangal, select a .doc document, choose Hindi as the input language and the relevant font as the ASCII font. For the output, select Hindi as the language and Unicode Mangal as the font. Browse for the file and select it. If you have Office 2007 and the Word document has a .docx extension, rename the extension .doc; the document will then appear in Browse. If you do not have Office 2007, renaming it will serve no purpose. Now click Convert: a new file will be created in the Unicode Mangal font. If your Word document contains a mixture of Unicode and ASCII fonts, select the ASCII font approximately, or the one used most frequently. Click Convert and it will be converted into Unicode Mangal.

Website Construction

First purchase a domain name from a reputable online organisation. For example, visit Rediff.com and click Rediff Hosting. Go to "Book Your Domain" and check whether the name you want is available. You can buy a suitable domain name for your website online with a credit card. It is inexpensive, costing at most ten dollars a year. Then go to the web-hosting link. Obtain hosting space of 100 MB for five or ten years. A MySQL service comes free with it, but that requires working with Linux, which may be somewhat difficult or technical; therefore you may purchase a Microsoft SQL service for a little extra money. You will then have a 20 MB SQL database and 80 MB of space for the site—a total of 100 MB—which is sufficient. More space can be arranged without charge, as will be discussed later. Once you have obtained the Microsoft SQL service, you can upload

your Microsoft Excel file and use it by building an interface on your website.

Now let us consider the procedure for creating a website.

Microsoft FrontPage comes with Office XP. It is also available separately with Office 2003.

Run the ready-made Website Wizard in FrontPage. A website of approximately five pages will be created. By right-clicking on the left side, you can increase the number of pages. You can also choose a ready-made design of your liking from the themes at the top. Using the Photo element, you can turn any webpage into a photo gallery and arrange photographs in three, four, five or six columns. Double-click on that page to import photographs from your computer and type descriptions with a Unicode typewriter. When saving the page, you can choose a JPEG image quality from 1 to 100. The larger the file, the more space it will occupy. After choosing the "Children" setting for the links on the left and at the bottom, information on all the website's pages will appear there. If there are many pages, you can create a sequence of pages within a page. Your website is now saved on your computer under My Documents/My Web.

Use the Preview option to examine the actual appearance of your website in the five browsers described above. After making the necessary changes in FrontPage, upload the site to your server. For this, visit FileZilla.com, which provides free software. Choose Client rather than Server and install the program on your computer. Then enter your username and password and upload the entire website to the server's root folder at ftp.yourdomainname. The website will then appear on the internet at its designated address.

Upload your database to the server by means of software such as EMS SQL Manager, and obtain any specialised information required by speaking to your service provider by telephone. Once all the material has been uploaded, do not forget to place your username and password in the HTML code of the interface page created on your website.

To add music to a page, import a music file from your computer onto that page. At present, however, music on a website made with FrontPage plays only in Opera and Internet Explorer.

Now a few remarks about page stylesheets.

If you wish to keep the entire website's design in one colour scheme, create a .css stylesheet for all the pages and place the design in one folder. It may also include music that plays in the background. The advantage is that the design need not be loaded anew whenever each page is opened: only the initial loading of the design and music takes time. The only additional

time spent on another page is that required for the text, photographs and other content on it. The website thus becomes lighter and opens faster.

Now let us learn about RSS feeds.

The website has been built; now it must also be publicised. RSS is the abbreviation of "Really Simple Syndication". Create one or more .xml files and upload them to your server. These then serve, in a sense, as a map of the website. Whenever a change occurs, the feed reader or aggregator is notified that new content has appeared. The feed contains summaries of major events, articles and other material, together with links. Clicking a link yields more detailed information. By supplying the address of an .xml page under Add Gadget/Feed in a blog, you can display updates for five to twenty new items (respectively on Google and WordPress blogs). RSS has other uses: notifying subscribers by email through FeedBurner, displaying a headline animator on a website or blog, emailing a link to desired material to a friend, and reading through a browser or a feed/news reader.

Next submit your website to Google, Yahoo Search, Live Search and Ask.com under "Submit Your Site" so that these search engines can find it. The web address of an .xml file makes it easier for these engines to find the material, providing free publicity for your site. An .xml file does not replace an .htm file; it helps feed aggregators and search engines discover new material. When you change your website, amend the original .xml file and upload it to your server; the feed aggregators and search engines will do the rest. Your internet browser can also refresh the website page if you select the feed option, since at times the browser displays older internet content from temporary files stored on the computer. For this, however, a code must be inserted on every page.

Now a few words about the 404 error page. If someone enters the address of a photograph or link that used to exist on your website but no longer does, the browser displays a 404 error. Obtain the configuration details from your service provider and create an error page to match your website's stylesheet. It should contain a personal message such as "The material you are looking for is no longer available" and links to other pages of the site. But take care to include code on that page preventing search engines from indexing it.

You can place the girgit.chitthajagat.in or Google Translate gadget on your website so that Maithili material can be converted into other scripts or languages with a single click.

Promote the site by creating your own blog or group. For online comment submissions, obtain the .NET facility from your service provider, so that the server can send readers' comments to your email address. You can increase readership by registering your feed with feed aggregators.

Comment submissions can also be obtained from TypePad.com, a paid blogging service; it charges for blogs but not for creating a profile, and provides both code and facilities for comment forms on blogs and websites. You can choose how many comments appear on a page, allow conversations in response to comments, and select comment-moderation options.

For your website's archive, Google Sites and WordPress provide 10 GB and 3 GB of free space respectively. Upload files there but place links to them on your own site. This helps you control your budget.

If you do not like your blog's URL, a customised URL is available for ten dollars annually, though this brings no additional facilities beyond those of the blog itself. If your budget is very small, however, use this option.

If you already have a full website, you can upload a discussion forum and similar facilities to one of its pages by FTP, and incorporate a blog into the site. Under Publishing in Blogger, both the ten-dollar-a-year URL facility and FTP upload are available.

Now let us discuss favicons. To display your logo beside the browser address, create an image of the logo in .ico format and upload it, specifying its location in the stylesheet. If you obtain the ten-dollar-a-year customised URL through Google under Blogger's Publishing section, the Google favicon will appear. In WordPress, however, you can use your own favicon both on an ordinary blog and on a blog with a customised domain name.

You can also publicise your e-journal through email signatures, MySpace, Facebook, Orkut, Twitter, YouTube, Picasa, Yahoo Groups and Google Groups, as well as RSS feeds and a headline animator, which can also be placed in an email signature.

Use Google Analytics and Webmaster Tools as well. Add the Analytics tracking code to every page so that you can learn each day who visited the website, where they came from and how they arrived. Verify the website through Webmaster Tools and submit the .xml file.

If you want a photograph or link on a page to open in another tab or browser window, select Target Frame/New Window—Blank.

When a PDF is saved as text, the Devanagari is sometimes not saved as Unicode—or as any readable text at all. If you copy text from a PDF and paste it into Uninagari, the Devanagari appears. An ASCII converter can also convert PDF text into Unicode, though the formatting is lost.

Among font converters, the SIL Converter is a free software tool that does not destroy the formatting.

C-DAC Pune also provides tools and fonts, but no particular benefit is apparent; instead, numerous problems arise, such as "द् ध" and "ग् र" appearing in place of द्ध and ग्र respectively.

An online Unicode typewriter is available on the Videha e-journal website, http://www.videha.co.in/. If you encounter particular difficulties or want an offline version, you can email me at ggajendra@videha.com to request it or ask further questions.

55. The Internet and Maithili

Abstract

The aim of electronic publishing on the internet should be to establish a forum that creates a medium between writer and reader, available from anywhere twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. Publication should be regular, bringing an end to distribution difficulties and geographical distance. As a further consequence of the revolution in information technology, it should also provide a forum for a new generation of readers and writers alongside the older ones.

Keywords: internet · critical theory · Maithili

Background

The aim of electronic publishing on the internet should be to establish a forum that creates a medium between writer and reader, available from anywhere twenty-four hours a day, seven days a week. Publication should be regular, bringing an end to distribution difficulties and geographical distance. As a further consequence of the revolution in information technology, it should also provide a forum for a new generation of readers and writers alongside the older ones. I began bringing Maithili onto the internet in 2000, through Yahoo GeoCities in 2000–2001, but all those sites were deleted when Yahoo discontinued the service. "Bhalsarik Gachh", created on 5 July 2004 and still available at http://www.videha.com/2004/07/bhalsarik-gachh.html, remains as an early manifestation of Maithili's presence on the internet. Initially, websites used ASCII fonts such as Kruti Dev and Shusha. They were useful then, but search engines now search Unicode UTF-8, and Devanagari typed in ASCII fonts is not searchable. Windows includes the Unicode Mangal font, and Devanagari written in it can be searched. The application for the Unicode form of Mithilakshar, submitted by Anshuman Pandey, remains pending. I too contributed at the request of Professor Deborah Anderson of UC Berkeley, Project Leader of the Script Encoding Initiative, Department of Linguistics. At first both readers and writers were few, but as Unicode-based search engines were developed by Google, Live and Ask.com, the number of Maithili readers and writers on the internet grew.

Maithili and the Internet

Here one finds everything: literature, news, Maithili audio, Maithili video, Mithila painting and electronic Maithili books.

Creating a Website in Maithili

First buy a domain name from a reputable online organisation. For example, visit Rediff.com and click Rediff Hosting. Choose "Book Your Domain" and check whether your preferred name is available. You can buy a suitable domain name for your website online by credit card. It is inexpensive: its maximum price is ten dollars a year. Then follow the link for web-hosting services. Obtain 100 MB of hosting space for five or ten years. MySQL comes free with it, but that requires working on Linux, which may be somewhat difficult or technical, so you can obtain Microsoft SQL for an additional fee. You will then have a 20 MB SQL database and 80 MB of website space, making 100 MB in all, which is sufficient. Having obtained Microsoft SQL, you can upload a Microsoft Excel file there and use it through an interface you create on the website. An online, SQL-based searchable dictionary also exists—the Videha Dictionary. For this, the database is uploaded to the server by software such as EMS SQL Manager, and an interface is provided on a website page.

Now let us consider how to create the website. Microsoft FrontPage comes with Office XP and is also available separately with Office 2003. Run the ready-made Website Wizard in FrontPage; it will create a website of about five pages. By right-clicking on the left, you can increase the number of pages. You may choose a ready-made design from the themes above. Using the Photo element, you can convert a webpage into a photo gallery and arrange pictures in three, four, five or six columns.

Google and WordPress offer many ready-made templates for creating blogs, with apparently unlimited data storage for writing, messages and comments and free hosting. These blog-building services are user-centred and provide facilities for straightforward writing.

Advantages and Disadvantages

The internet enables the rapid transmission of information, but its misuse may be even more likely than its proper use—particularly comments posted under assumed names through different internet service providers and attempts at blackmail. There are methods of exposing such activities, but pursuing them also wastes energy. Where internet speeds are low or access is expensive, material can be collected in PDF form. Readers can download the files, save them on their computers and read them when convenient. A computer must have the necessary font to read a file; otherwise, the simplest course is to convert a word-processed article into PDF. This has both benefits and drawbacks. The benefit is that a PDF can

be read without the difficulty of installing fonts, regardless of the typeface or script in which it was written. The drawback is that if "Save as Text" is used, English may be saved correctly while Devanagari becomes unreadable.

The internet has proved a blessing for Maithils living away from their homeland. It is remarkable how children and women, and readers and writers from communities other than Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas, have joined this Maithili activity.

Here, too, work is being done against the slow poisoning inflicted upon Maithili. There will be no compromise in Maithili's name: genuine Maithili readers, not self-serving coteries. These are not magazines without readers, locked in quarrels born of personal ambition, dying themselves while killing Maithili. Of course, caste-based quarrels and abusive language have also been observed on some Maithili blogs, and their perpetrators are people driven by personal ambition. Literary works published electronically on the internet receive the affection and online comments of thousands upon thousands of readers. National surveys show that those who fail to obtain admission to other subjects are the ones who study Sanskrit, Hindi, Maithili and other literatures in colleges; the same people also enter journalism. Such talent-poor devotees of literature have developed a taste for it: can the future of Maithili safely rest in their hands? The internet has intervened in a situation in which Maithili was dying from the rival ambitions of a narrow group of competitors—formidable competitors, indeed! There is an abundance of science fiction, stories and poems for children and adolescents. The gentle rises and falls of Mithila's language, the many-sided abilities of its proletarian classes, along with the region's rigidities of custom and culture, politics, everyday life, social beliefs, economic conditions, ethics, religion and philosophy—all are present here. Unedited compositions posted on blogs disprove the notion that only Maithil Brahmins can write good Maithili. Writers and readers other than Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas provide a model before Maithil readers and writers, showing that their objections were not mistaken: Maithili had been written incorrectly. Maithili literature is thus saved from becoming one-sided. The movement from the internet to print is also simple, because the publisher receives ready-made material and saves expense.

The Future of Maithili on the Internet

When the printing press first arrived, it was labelled the property of the bourgeois class. The novel, too, arose with the press and was regarded as bourgeois literature, but gradually that notion disappeared. Internet literature will likewise remain a complement to printed literature. Those who do not wish to read on a computer screen will read the text in print.

Print-on-demand facilities are also provided by Pothi.com and other websites and publishers.

For Maithili, the regularity of publication made possible by the internet, the elimination of distribution difficulties, virtually zero cost and the overcoming of geographical distance have proved a blessing.

56. Self-Image, Language Technology and Inclusive Communication

Abstract

Fashion an image of yourself that good people can love—an image of someone capable and diligent. Yet as we move forward and time passes, the inner image of many among us begins to deteriorate. This happens when we pay attention to what other people think or say about us. They may offer their pretended knowledge, or at times even genuine knowledge—information, one might say. But can they give us our own self-image or ability? No; more often they do the opposite.

Keywords: self · language · technology · inclusive · communication · also · signs

Editorial for the New Issue

Fashion an image of yourself that good people can love—an image of someone capable and diligent.

Is receiving awards and payment a measure of success? And is a lifetime of standing firm, like Subhash Chandra Yadav and Sushil, and paying the price for it a success or a failure?

The internet, too, is full of dangers. Neither manufacture nor spread fake news, and protect yourself from online criminals.

Do not intimidate or harass those younger or weaker than yourself. If someone does this to you, lodge a complaint against them.

Welcome only that development which does not destroy the environment. Plant ten times as many trees as you cut down.

Working alone can be frightening—even on the smallest task. Yet companionship and support will not always be available: neither people nor assistance can always be at your side.

Forget the past, whether it was good or bad.

It is not good to lose one's life for the sake of laughter and joking.

Chemical substances used in fields pollute the environment. Crops grown with organic inputs, without chemicals, are healthier and tastier.

Live simply, in a way that does not harm the environment; remain connected to nature.

Live in fellowship with one another—not with human beings alone, but with livestock, birds, all creatures, nature and streams.

And if this is how you live, understand that you belong to the parallel stream. You are welcome.

We should all read widely and keep learning new things.

Maithili Sign Language (Devanagari / Mithilakshar / Kaithi / Newari)

Maithili Sign Script (Sign Language)

Maithili sign script is a sign language for deaf and speech-impaired people.

American Sign Language (ASL) developed in the United States and British Sign Language (BSL) in Britain; both are used in many places around the world. ASL chiefly uses one hand, whereas BSL frequently uses both hands.

Sign scripts have also been developed in India and Nepal.

The sign language of India is called Indian Sign Language (ISL). The Indian Sign Language Research and Training Centre (http://www.islrtc.nic.in/) works on its development, standardisation and teaching. The ISL dictionary and some NCERT books in sign language are available through this link: https://www.youtube.com/@islrtcnewdelhi4069/playlists.

For Devanagari, which is based on the ka–ca–ṭa–ta–pa consonant classes, Ramesh M. Kagalkar (http://rameshkagalkar.appspot.com) developed a system in Marathi, while the Nepal National Federation of the Deaf & Hard of Hearing (NFDH) did so in Nepali. At the Empower Conference 2021, Amal Jude Ashwin, Sunil Kumar Kopparapu and V. Srinivasa Chakravarthy presented their conception for Tamil and other Indic scripts.

Schools for deaf and speech-impaired pupils generally teach something close to American Sign Language, but Indic scripts can be represented more effectively through British Sign Language. Maithili sign script (in Devanagari, Mithilakshar, Kaithi and Newari—all four based on the ka–ca–ṭa–ta–pa consonant classes) is based on British Sign Language (BSL) and uses both hands.

Sign-Language Videos

Sign script cannot be learned from books alone. NCERT has released sign-language videos in twenty-two languages. Links for Maithili, Nepali,

Marathi and Tamil appear below; links for all the remaining languages are supplied at the end of this book.

Maithili: https://youtu.be/J03T3E20JRM

Nepali: https://youtu.be/9_A3EK_fV24

Marathi: https://youtu.be/93BVVsJVUks

Tamil: https://youtu.be/6ecBHlL_Hu4

These videos have the following features:

1. They also contain sound, and are therefore useful not only to deaf and speech-impaired viewers but also to other people, including those with visual disabilities.

2. The videos use sign script in conjunction with the audio.

3. Transcripts also appear in the videos, with Hindi and English translations alongside the language concerned. At https://ncert.nic.in/bs-2021.php, PDF files for all twenty-two languages are also available. Besides Hindi and English translations, the text in each language's own script is given in Devanagari and Roman transcription.

Sign-Language Dictionary

The sign-language dictionary is available at http://www.islrtc.nic.in/.

RESOURCES:

ISL project of the Indian Sign Language Research and Training Centre: http://www.islrtc.nic.in/

ISLRTC YouTube channel—ISL dictionary and selected NCERT books: https://www.youtube.com/@islrtcnewdelhi4069/playlists

Ramesh M. Kagalkar: http://rameshkagalkar.appspot.com

Nepal National Federation of the Deaf & Hard of Hearing (NFDH)

Empowering persons with speech and hearing disabilities through a unified finger-spelling method for Indic scripts—https://empower2021.iiitb.ac.in/paper2021/. Authors: (1) Amal Jude Ashwin F., Bhupat & Jyoti Mehta School of Biosciences, Department of Biotechnology, IIT Madras, India; (2) Sunil Kumar Kopparapu, TCS Research, Tata Consultancy Services Limited, India; (3) V. Srinivasa Chakravarthy, Bhupat & Jyoti Mehta School of Biosciences, Department of Biotechnology, IIT Madras, India.

Sign-language videos in twenty-two languages:
https://www.youtube.com/@videha_ejournal (courtesy: Bhasha Sangam—
https://ncert.nic.in/bs-2021.php)

Maithili: https://youtu.be/J03T3E20JRM

Nepali: https://youtu.be/9_A3EK_fV24

Marathi: https://youtu.be/93BVVsJVUks

Konkani: https://youtu.be/gTjPY_ebTfU

Gujarati: https://youtu.be/kEVuF08mYuM

Sanskrit: https://youtu.be/IU60_0NSckQ

Bangla: https://youtu.be/JTr0w8vVTtA

Assamese: https://youtu.be/MpX9d-NI7dg

Odia: https://youtu.be/XROIdeGqnXk

Santali: https://youtu.be/3lxtfz3_R-c

Hindi: https://youtu.be/2PoOrwsnY88

Urdu: https://youtu.be/6UWTq5Z9U2c

Punjabi: https://youtu.be/gWw4IQFCZ2w

Dogri: https://youtu.be/DPKtPI9qJbY

Kashmiri: https://youtu.be/vIVr4E5H-6c

Bodo: https://youtu.be/DhRLfc-uWLA

Sindhi: https://youtu.be/SJAmLreMz4s

Tamil: https://youtu.be/6ecBHlL_Hu4

Malayalam: https://youtu.be/nW9e5eO6a_E

Kannada: https://youtu.be/U0SdbM9Qs1w

Telugu: https://youtu.be/_Gz1Sudph3Q

Manipuri: https://youtu.be/WBHcO-wShJk

2

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Keyman Tirhuta / Vedic Sanskrit Keyboard for Windows / Mac OS / Linux Ubuntu-Wasta / Linux Debian / Android / Apple iPhone–iPad / Web

ॐ द्यौ. षान्ठिवन्ठेविऋ॑ षान्ठिः

ॐ द्यौः शान्तिरन्तरिक्ष ग्वंग शान्तिः

I.

FOR WINDOWS DESKTOP

For Windows, go to: https://keyman.com/windows/download.php

OR

To search for a Tirhuta keyboard, go to: https://keyman.com/keyboards?q=tirhuta

If you are comfortable with the Remington/Inscript keyboard, download the "Tirhuta" keyboard from https://downloads.keyman.com/windows/stable/16.0.138/keyman-setup.tirhuta.exe?_ga=2.26983796.856782072.1678802904-87949676.1676042074. It uses the "Mithila Uni" font. If you prefer phonetic typing, download the "Malar Tirhuta" keyboard from https://downloads.keyman.com/windows/stable/16.0.138/keyman-setup.malar_tirhuta.exe?_ga=2.26983796.856782072.1678802904-87949676.1676042074. It uses the "Noto Sans Tirhuta" font.

For a Vedic Sanskrit phonetic keyboard: https://downloads.keyman.com/windows/stable/16.0.138/keyman-setup.itrans_devanagari_sanskrit_vedic.exe?_ga=2.267216455.856782072.1678802904-87949676.1676042074

II.

FOR APPLE MAC OS

For a Mac, go to https://keyman.com/mac/download.php and download the software.

III.

FOR LINUX DESKTOP

For Linux: https://keyman.com/linux/download.php

IV.

FOR ANDROID PHONES

On an Android phone, open the Google Play Store and download the Keyman app; details: https://keyman.com/android/

V.

FOR APPLE iPHONE / iPAD (iOS)

On your phone or tablet, open the Apple App Store and download the Keyman app; details: https://keyman.com/iphone-and-ipad/

VI.

FOR AN ONLINE WEB TYPEWRITER

Go to: https://keymanweb.com/

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I

Ramchandra Ray, Known as Ramu Sir, and His Collection of Short and Long Stories, Sapna Sakar

In the story "Tohī Jitlē, Hamhī Hāralaũ" ("You Won, I Lost") from Sapna Sakar, the collection of short and long stories by Ramchandra Ray, popularly known as Ramu Sir, we encounter people of the so-called upper castes and other castes living together. Naveen's parents intend to complete the kaubala-pati transaction from his first salary; then an inter-caste love story unfolds. As often happens in a love affair, an abduction complaint is filed here too. But Nunu Bhaiya eventually agrees. It will not take anyone long to recognise the autobiographical element in Sapna Sakar. There is also a new way of removing a ceremonial garland worn around the neck, and a pledge by eleven young men against ritualism and death-feasts. The collection encompasses a woman's life cast aside, mental illness and much else. The woman dismissed as mad was not mad at all. In her parental home she had been considered fortunate; after marriage, however...

The finest stories in the collection, however, are the long stories "Nirvāsit Jīvan" ("Exiled Life") and "Budhni Māik Bethā" ("Budhni Mother's Pain").

In "Budhni Māik Bethā", the presence of women at the panchayat meeting is heartening; at the same time, the description does not omit Budhni Mother's dilapidated house built under the Indira Awas scheme. There is suspense: Budhni Mother is about to reveal the name. Charan Babu rebukes her: how could she remain alive after committing such a sin? The young men should burn her alive. Budhni begins: "My respects to all the panchas!" If I am lying, may lightning strike my body, may my limbs fail me. Does this recall Sita entering the earth? During the flood the embankment broke. She survived by washing the householders' pots and utensils for wages, but even that work was denied her. Yet, on her way here, she had seen Jagat... Without carrying out any inquiry, the panchas declare that Jagat had made her an illegitimate mother and leave. In the face of Jagat's influence, hardly anyone dares speak. Late at night the mother and daughter, at the urging of three young men, set out for the police station, but Jagat's influence reaches even there. Yet still... The police, however, belong to no one—not even their own father. Some young men provide a ray of hope. Budhni Mother will give birth to the child. She does not understand DNA, but she knows that there is some sort of test and that the test will prove Jagat to be the father.

"Nirvāsit Jīvan" is also an accomplished long story. Its first distinctive feature is its use of human irony, which the storyteller captures so well. A

theft in Bharamwali's house! Had the thief's own cleverness been stolen? Bharamwali Bhabhi, however, understands that this is no theft: someone is deliberately making trouble for her. On hearing this, Bhutkun Bhai becomes impatient to hear her story.

A second distinguishing feature of this long story is its close observation and recording of everyday human life. Bhutkun can go there on the pretext of discussing earthwork, but Bhabhi's house has no front verandah; how could he walk straight into the courtyard? Bhabhi blushes to see men relieving themselves along the edge of the open fields, although the men themselves feel no embarrassment. But what if a woman were to do the same? There is the sting of a male-dominated society. Yet women have now advanced in education, and the government has granted them half the reservations.

The third distinctive feature is the author's wealth of vocabulary, indispensable to recording the life of Bharamwali Bhabhi.

"Nirvāsit Jīvan" and "Budhni Māik Bethā" possess a novelistic breadth, and in Ramu Sir I see a future novelist for Maithili.

2

The 112th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray Held at Sahuria–Navtoli

The 112th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray literary gathering devoted to short fiction was held on Saturday, 25 March 2023, at the Abhinav Shiksha Niketan campus in Sahuria–Navtoli, within Shiva Panchayat near Andhrabazar in Madhubani district. The event was convened by the well-known storyteller Shri Ramchandra Ray, also known as Ramu Sir. It was inaugurated through the joint lighting of the ceremonial lamp by Dr Rampreet Paswan, former Minister of the Public Health Engineering Department of the Bihar Government; Dr Kamalkant Jha and Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal, recipients of Sahitya Akademi awards for 2020 and 2021 respectively; Dr Dhanakar Thakur, President of the International Maithili Literary Council; Shri Arvind Prasad, Secretary of the Progressive Writers' Association, Madhubani; Shri Brahmanand Prasad, advocate of the Delhi High Court; and senior writer Shri Ramshreshtha Diwana. The guests seated on the dais were honoured with garlands and new garments, and Shri Ramchandra Ray, who conducted the inaugural session, took the programme forward. First, Sushri Shashiprabha and Sushri Chanda Kumari presented a welcome song. Thereafter I (Umesh Mandal), in my welcome address, briefly introduced this journey of storytelling undertaken by Sagar Rati Deep Jaray. I said that among the many forums dedicated to the development of Maithili literature, this alone is a platform that places no restriction on anyone's attendance. For the development of Maithili fiction, Sagar Rati Deep Jaray is regarded as a

workshop for storytellers and critics. As the inaugural session continued, ten books across different genres were released. A distinguished presidium was then constituted for the storytelling session, bringing to the dais Sahityashri Pritam Kumar Nishad, Shri Ram Vilas Sahu, Dr Shiv Kumar Prasad, Professor Rameshwar Prasad Mandal, Shri Kapileshwar Raut, Shri Umesh Narayan Karn and Pandit Shiv Kumar Mishra. Shri Narayan Yadav, Shri Durganand Mandal, Shri Baijnathi Ram and Shri Nand Vilas Ray were also invited to conduct the all-night session. Along with honouring everyone, each storyteller and critic was presented with a new garment and flower garland. Across successive rounds, thirty-four stories were read and, as in previous gatherings, the readings were followed by critical commentary. At six in the morning, the lamp and the register were handed over to the next convenor, Shri Narayan Yadav. On receiving them, Yadav announced that the next lamp of Sagar Rati Deep Jaray would be lit in the village of Nahri (Khutauna) on the last Saturday of June.

Details of the books released and stories read on the occasion follow.

Books released: 1. Sapna Sakar (short-story collection)—Shri Ramchandra Ray (Ramu Sir); 2. Upayan (poetry collection)—Shri Rajkishor Mishra; 3. Jagdish Prasad Mandal: Ek Jivani (biography)—Shri Rameshwar Prasad Mandal; 4. Nachi Rahal Chhali Vasudha (novel)—Shri Rabindra Narayan Mishra; 5. Antardhvani (story anthology)—Dr Umesh Mandal; 6. Jagdish P. Mandal Maithili Writer—Shri Gajendra Thakur; 7. Sehanta Sehante Rahi Gel (short-story collection)—Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal; 8. Sunayana Beti (novel)—Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal; 9. Mithila Saput Dr Gurmaita—Dr Kamalkant Jha; 10. Mobilek Lila (personal essays)—Dr Kamalkant Jha.

Story Readings

1. Ghatait–Barhait Chanda Mama—Divya Chandra; 2. Gobar Bichhni—Narayan Yadav; 3. Ghi Ketay Herael Ta Dalime—Nand Vilas Ray; 4. Bahuguni Roti—Janak Lal Mandal; 5. Dekhalapar Dekhab—Pallavi Mandal; 6. Time Pass—Dhanakar Thakur; 7. Parhab Kena—Ravibhushan Kumar; 8. Madhumachhi a Machhi—Ram Vilas Sahu; 9. Mobile School—Chandra Mohan Acharya; 10. Kahbi Phel—Kamalkant Jha; 11. Burkawali —Umesh Narayan Karn; 12. Charim Katha—Manab Anish Mandal; 13. Chakbidor—Rameshwar Prasad Mandal; 14. Dinosaur Hebas Banchau—Arvind Prasad; 15. Premak Rishta—Durganand Mandal; 16. Parchhanhi—Jholi Paswan; 17. Purana Sweater—Ritik Kumar; 18. Asal Chor Ke—Dr Veena Prasad; 19. Sahodar—Kumar Sunil Narayan; 20. Maik Mamta—Jagdish Mandal; 21. Televisionak Musalman—Ram Naresh Yadav; 22. Sanesak Gachh—Radhakant Mandal; 23. Appan Aasa—Pritam Kumar Nishad; 24. Gobar Karhni—Kapileshwar Raut; 25. Das Varshak Bad—Umesh Mandal; 26. Sthanak Mahatva—Shiv Kumar Mishra; 27. Aamak

Khetime Gayak Yogdan—Bechan Thakur; 28. Bhagwan Bhukhale Na Rakhay Chhathi—Gauri Shankar Sah; 29. Kanphuski—Santosh Kumar Ray; 30. Parishramak Phal—Parmanand Kumar Ray; 31. Babujiak Arman —Satyanarayan Vyas; 32. Dalit Majdur—Baijnathi Ram; 33. Shortcut Rasta —Jagdish Prasad Mandal; 34. Nashamukta Gam—Ramchandra Ray (Ramu Sir).

The Storytelling Journey of Sagar Rati Deep Jaray: From the First to the 112th Gathering

1. Muzaffarpur — 21.01.1990; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.

2. Deorh — 29.04.1990; Jivakant.

3. Darbhanga — 07.07.1990; Dr Bhimnath Jha, Pradip Maithili Putra, Vijaykant Thakur.

4. Patna — 03.11.1990; Govind Jha, Damankant Jha.

5. Begusarai — 13.01.1991; Pradip Bihari.

6. Katihar — 22.04.1991; Ashok.

7. Nawani — 21.07.1991; Mohan Bharadwaj.

8. Sakri — 22.10.1991; Professor Sureshwar Jha, Dr Ram Babu.

9. Nehra — 11.10.1992; A. C. Deepak.

10. Biratnagar — 14.04.1992; Jitendra Jit.

11. Varanasi — 18.07.1992; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.

12. Patna — 19.10.1992; Rajmohan Jha.

13. Supaul–1 — 18.10.1993; Kedar Kanan.

14. Bokaro — 24.04.1993; Buddhinath Jha.

15. Paitghat — 10.07.1993; Dr Ramanand Jha ‘Raman’.

16. Janakpur — 09.10.1994; Ramesh Ranjan.

17. Isahpur — 06.02.1994; Dr Arvind Kumar ‘Akku’.

18. Sarhad — 23.04.1994; Amiya Kumar Jha.

19. Jhanjharpur — 09.07.1994; Shyamanand Chaudhary.

20. Ghoghardihā — 22.10.1994; Dr Narayanji.

21. Bahera — 21.01.1995; Kamlesh Jha.

22. Supaul (Darbhanga) — 08.04.1995; Kamlesh Jha.

23. Kathmandu — 23.09.1995; Dhirendra Premarshi.

24. Rajbiraj — 24.01.1996; Ramnarayan Dev.

25. Kolkata (Silver Jubilee) — 28.12.1996; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.

26. Mahishi — 13.04.1997; Dr Taranand Viyogi; sponsored by Ramesh.

27. Tarauni — 20.06.1997; Shobhakant.

28. Patna — 18.07.1997; Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary.
29. Begusarai — 13.09.1997; Pradip Bihari.
30. Khajauli — 04.04.1998; Pradip Bihari.
31. Saharsa — 18.07.1998; Ramesh.
32. Patna — 10.10.1998; Shyam Darihare.
33. Balain; Nagdah — 08.01.1999; Padam Sambhav.
34. Bhawanipur — 10.04.1999; Dr Jishnu Dutt Mishra.
35. Madhubani — 24.07.1999; Siyaram Jha 'Saras', Dr Kuldhari Singh.
36. Andauli — 20.10.1999; Kamlesh Jha.
37. Janakpur — 25.03.2000; Ramesh Ranjan.
38. Kathmandu — 25.06.2000; Dhirendra Premarshi.
39. Dhanbad — 21.10.2000; Shyam Darihare and Ramchandra Laldas.
40. Bittho — 21.01.2001; Dr Akku, Professor Vidyanand Jha.
41. Hatni (Ghoghardihā) — 19.05.2001; Professor Yoganand Jha / Ajit Kumar Azad.
42. Bokaro — 25.08.2001; Girijanand Jha 'Ardhanarishwar', Mithila Sahitya Parishad.
43. Patna (Kiran Jayanti) — 01.12.2001; Ashok, Chetna Samiti, Patna.
44. Ranchi — 13.04.2002; Kumar Manish Arvind.
45. Bhagalpur — 24.08.2002; Dhirendra Mohan Jha.
46. Patna (Vidyapati Bhavan) — 16.11.2002; Ajit Kumar Azad.
47. Kolkata — 22.01.2003; Karna Goshthi, Kolkata.
48. Khutauna — 07.06.2003; Dr Mahendra Narayan Ram.
49. Benipur — 20.09.2003; Kamlesh Jha.
50. Darbhanga — 21.02.2004; Dr Ashok Kumar Mehta.
51. Jamshedpur — 10.07.2004; Dr Ravindra Kumar Chaudhary.
52. Ranchi — 02.10.2004; Vivekanand Thakur.
53. Deoghar — 08.01.2005; Shyam Darihare and Avinash.
54. Begusarai — 09.04.2005; Pradip Bihari.
55. Purnia — 20.06.2005; Ramesh.
56. Patna — 03.11.2005; Ajit Kumar Azad.
57. Janakpur (Nepal) — 12.08.2006; Ramesh Ranjan.
58. Jaynagar — 02.12.2006; Narayan Yadav.
59. Begusarai — 10.02.2007; Pradip Bihari.
60. Saharsa — 21.07.2007; Kislay Krishna.
61. Supaul–2 — 01.12.2007; Arvind Thakur.

62. Jamshedpur — 03.05.2008; Dr Ravindra Kumar Chaudhary.

63. Ranchi — 19.07.2008; Kumar Manish Arvind.

64. Rahua Sangram (Madhubani) — 08.11.2008; Dr Ashok Avichal.

65. Patna (Katha Ganga–3) — 21.02.2009; Ajit Kumar Azad / Chetna Samiti.

66. Madhubani — 30.05.2009; Dilip Kumar Jha.

67. Samastipur — 05.09.2009; Ramakant Ray 'Rama'.

68. Supaul–3 — 05.12.2009; Arvind Thakur.

69. Janakpur — 03.04.2010; Rajaram Singh 'Rathore'.

70. Kabilpur (Darbhanga) — 12.06.2010; Dr Yoganand Jha.

71. Berma (Jhanjharpur) — 02.10.2010; Jagdish Prasad Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

72. Supaul — 04.12.2010; Arvind Thakur.

73. Mahishi (Katha Rajkamal) — 05.03.2011; Vijay Mahapatra.

74. Hazaribagh — 10.09.2011; Shyam Darihare.

75. Patna (Diamond Jubilee) — 10.12.2011; Ashok and Kamalmohan 'Chunnu'.

76. Chennai — 14.07.2012; Vibha Rani.

77. Darbhanga (Kiran Jayanti) — 01.12.2012; Arvind Thakur.

78. Ghanshyampur — 09.03.2013; Kamlesh Jha.

79. Auraha (Laukahi) — 15.05.2013; Umesh Paswan.

80. Nirmali (Supaul) — 30.11.2013; Umesh Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

81. Deoghar (Bijli Kothi, Bampas Town) — 22.03.2014; Om Prakash Jha.

82. Mehath (Jhanjharpur; Katha Bauddha Siddha Mehathpa) — 31.05.2014; Gajendra Thakur.

83. Sakhua–Bhaptiahi — 30.08.2014; Nand Vilas Ray / Fagulal Sahu / Suraj Narayan Ray 'Suman'.

84. Berma (Madhubani) — 20.12.2014; Shiv Kumar Mishra and local literature enthusiasts.

85. Bhagalpur (Shyam Kunj, Dwarikapuri) — 04.04.2015; Om Prakash Jha.

86. Laksena (Madhubani) — 20.06.2015; Rajdev Mandal 'Raman', Satyadev 'Suman'.

87. Nirmali (Supaul) — 19.09.2015; Umesh Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

88. Dakhram Middle School (Benipur) — 30.01.2016; Kamlesh Jha, Amar Nath Jha.

89. Laukahi — 26.03.2016; Umesh Paswan and Prem Kumar Sahu.

90. Lakshminiya (Madhubani) — 18.06.2016; Ram Vilas Sahu and local literature enthusiasts.

91. Godhanpur (Madhubani) — 24.09.2016; Durganand Mandal.

92. Nawani (Madhubani) — 31.12.2016; Ajay Kumar Das ‘Pintu’.

93. Ratansara (Ghoghardihā) — 25.03.2017; Rajdev Mandal and local literature enthusiasts.

94. Laufa (Madhepur) — 24.06.2017; Dr Yogendra Pathak Viyogi and local enthusiasts.

95. Jalsain Dumra (Madhubani) — 09.09.2017; Narayan Yadav.

96. Dhabouli (Laukahi) — 16.12.2017; Radhakant Mandal.

97. Berma (Lakhnaur) — 24.03.2018; Kapileshwar Raut and Berma villagers.

98. Simra (Jhanjharpur) — 16.06.2018; Dr Shiv Kumar Prasad.

99. Murhaddi (Barki Tol) — 22.09.2018; Professor Pritam Nishad.

100. Nirmali (Terapanth Bhavan) — 22.12.2018; Umesh Mandal, Navratna Vengani, Manish Jalan.

101. Jhitki (Madhubani) — 30.03.2019; Bharat Bhushan Jha.

102. Majhaura (Madhubani) — 29.06.2019; Jai Prakash Mandal, Alok Kumar.

103. Rampur (Madhubani) — 28.09.2019; Umesh Narayan Karna ‘Kalpa Kavi’.

104. Valam Nagar–Mahdeva (Laukahi) — 14.12.2019; Prem Kumar Sahu, Umesh Paswan.

105. Darbhanga (Sitayan Auditorium) — 13.02.2021; Kamlesh Jha.

106. Hatni (Ghoghardihā, Madhubani) — 25.09.2021; Laldev Kamat.

107. Belha (Phulparas; in memory of Jivakant) — 25.12.2021; Umesh Mandal, Engineer Shailendra Mandal.

108. Madhura (Madhubani) — 26.03.2022; Dr Shreeshankar Jha.

109. Nanaur (Madhubani) — 25.06.2022; Pradip Pushp.

110. Sonvarsha (Laukahi) — 24.09.2022; Achchhelal Shastri and local literature enthusiasts.

111. Rahua Sangram (Madhubani) — 31.12.2022; Ashok Avichal.

112. Sahuria (Andhratharhi) — 25.03.2023; Ramchandra Ray.

The 113th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray is scheduled for the last Saturday of June 2023, to be convened by Shri Narayan Yadav in Nahri village (Khutauna).

The 111th Sagar Rati Deep Jaray Held at Rahua Sangram

PART II — APPLIED STUDIES

Section C — Applied Criticism

Folklore, History and Culture

1. Mayanand Mishra's Sense of History: In Relation to Prathamam Shail Putri Cha, Mantraputra, Purohit and Stri-Dhan

Abstract

This essay does not, as far as possible, revisit the narrative design and literary analysis already undertaken for Mayanandji's four books—Stri-Dhan, Purohit, Mantraputra and Prathamam Shail Putri Cha—but instead examines them exclusively from the perspective of historical consciousness. The essay reviews a historical journey completed by the author over roughly two decades through these four historical novels.

Keywords: Mayanand · Mishra · historical consciousness · Prathamam · Shail · Putri · Mantraputra

This essay does not, as far as possible, revisit the narrative design and literary analysis already undertaken for Mayanandji's four books—Stri-Dhan, Purohit, Mantraputra and Prathamam Shail Putri Cha—but instead considers them only in relation to historical consciousness.

This essay examines the historical journey completed by the author over nearly two decades, as represented in Mayanandji's four historical novels: (1) Prathamam Shail Putri Cha, (2) Mantraputra, (3) Purohit and (4) Stri-Dhan. Of these works, Mantraputra is in Maithili and the other three novels are in Hindi. Nevertheless, to understand the journey as a whole, maintain the continuity of the sequence and complete the criticism, it was essential to use all four books.

In chronological terms, Prathamam Shail Putri Cha comes first, taking as its historical basis the period before 1500 BCE. Mantraputra is based on the history of 1500–1200 BCE. These periods precede the Bharata war. Purohit covers 1200–1000 BCE, which may be described as the age of Brahmana literature. Stri-Dhan is set in Mithila in the age of the Sutras and Smritis.

The works were not, however, composed in this order. Mantraputra in Maithili was written first, in November 1986. Prathamam Shail Putri Cha followed two years later, and in it Mayanandji outlined the plan for all four books, though in the context of Hindi. Subsequently all the books appeared in Hindi. Mantraputra was published in Hindi, and partly on that

account the third book, Purohit, appeared rather late, in 1999. Stri-Dhan, the final book in the series, was published in 2007.

The preface to Prathamam Shail Putri Cha is called Kavach ("Armour"). The preface to Mantraputra is called Richalok and is placed at the end of the book: as this was the author's first historical work, placing the preface at the end sustained its mystery and suspense. The preface to Purohit is called Viniyog; before it stands the Durvakshat mantra, described here as the first patriotic song of India and of the world. In Mithila, this is used as a mantra of blessing. Its arguments for and against will be discussed in detail later.

The preface to Stri-Dhan is titled Lekhak Prishthabhumi ("The Author's Background"), an entirely appropriate designation because it provides the novel's historical background.

I have examined Mayanand's historical consciousness on the basis of shruti, tradition, reasoning and linguistics. This approach seeks to avoid Indian historiography constructed from the remnants of Western scholarly interpretations, and attempts to prevent the slightest influence of Central Asia or Europe upon the critical assessment.

1. Prathamam Shail Putri Cha—After the preface entitled Kavach ("Armour"), the book is divided into seventeen parts: (1) Agnā; (2) Agna–Shailā; (3) Shailā–Karālī; (4) Karālī–Mahesh; (5) Mahesh–Pārvatī; (6) Ganesh; (7) Harkisan; (8) Kisan; (9) Harappā: Moan Village; (10) The Auspicious Beginning of Ganesh; (11) Kishn; (12) Mahājan; (13) Maṇḍal; (14) Kishn Maṇḍal; (15) Maṇḍal: Maṇḍalī; (16) The Fall: Purandar; and (17) Epilogue: Migration.

1. Agnā—The novel opens in 2000 BCE with a description of people living in caves. Bā is the strongest man in a group; an ancestral Bā was strong too. Bā is the father of numerous children. The ancestral Bā had discovered two stones, one small and the other large. Am was called the dalāgrā, or leader of the band. Bā was also the name of a foul-smelling animal. Hands acquired increasing importance as people drew farther away from the trees. They knew from their ancestors that snakes were not to be killed and eaten. The first ancient deity was the tree; the second was the serpent deity, and the third the river deity. Bā had been having children with Ambā. A new axe and a new cutting implement were discovered. When the wild beasts were seen fleeing at the sight of "ah, āh, ag, agg," people gained knowledge of it. The women increased their numbers. The first woman received the name Agnā. Her male companion was Agg. Agnā became the dalāgrā, and under her leadership the group moved northwards. The author then states that the earth came into being some two billion years ago and regards this as entirely correct. A ritual formula reads, "ब्राह्मणे

द्वितीये परार्धे श्री स्वेतवाराह कल्पे वैवस्वत मन्वंतरे अष्ठाविंशतितमे कलियुगे प्रथम चरणे." On calculating from this, the age of the earth is found to be 1,972,949,032 years. The radioactive method, too, is said to yield the same answer. In Europe, until the seventeenth century, the age of the earth was held to be 4,000 years. Iranian scholars placed the creation of the earth 1,200 years in the past. From a scientific standpoint, both views appear ridiculous.

The second part begins with Agnā–Shailā, set in 10,000 BCE. In it Mayanand Mishra depicts the beginnings of language. The relationship between sign language and sound is brought out particularly well. The transition from a wandering to a settled way of life is also shown. Thereafter begins the chapter Shailā–Karālī, set 7,500 years ago. Cattle-keeping is discussed, and the number of cows has increased considerably. Everyone is a herdsman, wearing animal skins and carrying a stone weapon at the waist. There are sheep, goats and pigs, as well as some other domesticated animals. Grass ropes, tridents and the serpent deity are mentioned. Bā's name now becomes Ojā, while the dalāgrā is named Shailā Karālī. As the number of animals rises, cattle theft also begins. Meetings begin to be held under the peepal tree. Karālī receives the name Ambā.

In the chapter Karālī–Mahesh, the beginning of agriculture is depicted in 5000 BCE. Mahesh is sowing seed. There is mention of roasting barley before eating it. Watercourses now begin to be given names. The consumption of the meat of domesticated animals becomes absolutely forbidden within Mahesh's clan. Ojā remains seated at the site of the liṅga.

Then the chapter Mahesh–Pārvatī begins, four to five thousand years ago. Rice cultivation has commenced. When Pārvatī arrives, red earth is applied to her forehead according to the prevailing custom. Her son is named Ganesh. Before this, the parentage of children was not disclosed.

Ganesh—This chapter begins four thousand years ago. It introduces discussions of relations between men and women and the emergence of the paternal clan. The practice of obtaining and consuming salt begins; the clan that brings salt is named Nonī. Barley and wheat cultivation commence, as does the milking of cattle. The domestication of elephants begins, and exchange by barter also makes its appearance. The offering of water and leaves to the phallic deity begins. Barley is now pounded and ground to powder. Wheat is crushed, soaked in water and cooked over a fire. A separate group is engaged in keeping birds. Funeral rites and mourning for the dead begin. Writing, too, makes its appearance.

Har—The chapter is set at the beginning of 3500 BCE. Trade in salt and the making of well-designed boats begin. The pailī is conceived as an instrument of measurement. The plough begins to be used together with

oxen. Wells are dug, and settlements begin to spread sideways as well as lengthwise. Houses are also constructed. People of dark, fair and copper-coloured complexions continue to arrive in succession.

The chapter Harkisan begins 3,400 years ago. With agricultural development, the inclination towards permanent settlement grows, and the form of the family gradually becomes clearer. Agricultural development also heightens the need to expand trade. Woollen clothing, grinding mills, houses with walls, and enclosures around wells begin to be made.

The chapter Kisan begins in 3300 BCE. The sale of labour commences. Agriculture develops rapidly with the advent of irrigation. Greater geographical knowledge promotes trade. The use of ornaments grows.

The chapter Harappā: Mohan Village is set 3,200 years ago. A settlement of woodworkers is cited as an example of the selling of labour. Ornamentation becomes increasingly common. Alongside necklaces of beads, the potter's wheel appears. Class divisions begin to emerge in society.

The chapter The Auspicious Beginning of Ganesh starts in 3100 BCE. The author speaks of Harappā being built by people arriving from the south. Mohenjo-daro, Lothal and Chanhudaro develop as commercial centres. The script, the kaṭahī cart and the art of sculpture are invented, and markets begin to assemble for barter. The author discusses the Mesopotamian flood and the coming of Sumerians and Asuras.

The chapter Kishn begins in 3000 BCE. Overseas trade commences. Copper is discovered. Agricultural slavery also begins. Raised mounds are constructed for protection against floods.

The chapter Mahājan begins in 2800 BCE. Towns arise for the purposes of commerce. Canals are built for irrigation. The beam balance is invented as a matter of necessity. Arrangements for lighting are devised.

The chapter Maṇḍal concerns 2600 BCE. Institutions and the marriage system begin to take shape, and sailing boats are made for long-distance journeys.

The chapter Kishn Maṇḍal begins in the period of 2400 BCE. It discusses a lack of rainfall, together with the fear among the people occasioned by reports that the Aryans are advancing eastwards.

The chapter Maṇḍal: Maṇḍalī begins in 2200 BCE. In view of both the arrival of the Aryans and the absence of rain, Lothal begins to develop as an alternative centre.

The Fall: Purandar—The period of this chapter begins in 2000 BCE. Mayanandji ends his first book, Prathamam Shail Putri Cha, with an account of an Aryan king breaking down the fortified cities and

destroying the great centre of Harappā. The novel is written on the basis of such theories as the Aryans' calling Harappā Hariyūpiyā and their arrival from outside India, and it claims the status of a historical novel. Its historical narrative extends from 20,000 BCE to 1800 BCE. Yet judged in the light of original historical thinking and new research, many of its propositions do not appear sound.

The narrative beginning with Agnā had inspired great expectations. In the first chapter the author writes that the earth originated approximately two billion years ago, which he considers entirely correct. A ritual formula states, "ब्राह्मणे द्वितीये परार्धे श्री स्वेतवाराह कल्पे वैवस्वत मन्वंतरे अष्टाविंशतितमे कलियुगे प्रथम चरणे"; by calculating on this basis, the earth's age is obtained as 1,972,949,032 years. The radioactive method, too, is said to give the same answer. It is estimated that 1.67 parts of uranium change into lead over 100,000,000 years. Different stones and rocks contain different proportions of lead. Calculations of this kind indicate that radioactive substances existed 1,500,000,000 years ago; on this reasoning no rock could be more than 2,000,000,000 years old. Until the seventeenth century, Europe continued to accept an age of 4,000 years for the earth. Iranian scholars placed its creation 1,200 years ago. The author dismisses such Western research in the first chapter, but by the time he reaches the end he himself falls under the influence of a Western prejudice of the same kind—the notion, for example, that the Aryans called Harappā Hariyūpiyā. He could not free himself from the leavings of Western scholarship and subject the Śruti tradition to the test of reason. Consequently, Prathamam Shail Putri Cha fails to construct its historical narrative convincingly as literature on the following grounds:

Archaeological, linguistic and literary evidence supports the view that the Aryans were indigenous to India. The Aryan language family was named by Max Müller, and the Dravidian family by the missionary Robert Caldwell. The theory of an Aryan invasion emerged from a footnote in Griffith's translation of the Rigveda. Since these names were first assigned by foreign scholars, they must have had purposes of their own.

The Saraswati River; the great flood; the stories of Manu and the great fish; the Epic of Gilgamesh; Gilgamesh's search for the land of the living; accounts of creation; and the evolution of the pantheon—all these, when analysed as forms of social development, provide evidence that the Aryans were native to India.

The Rigveda contains a preponderance of feminine plural forms, preserving a memory of a matriarchal social order.

Voiced and aspirated sounds are characteristic of Rigvedic and Indian-language phonology; they are not found in the same form in either

Iranian or European languages. The civilisation between the Saraswati and Sindhu rivers was the civilisation of the Aryans. The Bharatas, Purus and other tribal groups dwelling on the banks of the Saraswati jointly composed the Rigveda. After a flood in the Saraswati, this civilisation moved from the Saraswat region to Kuru-Panchala and the Brahmarshi region, or Madhyadesha. The Bharatas then lost their importance in history. It is also possible that, after this flood, descendants of the Aryan people founded the cities of Mohenjo-daro and Harappā. Of the 800 sites of Harappan civilisation, more than 530 lay on the banks of the vanished Saraswati. These centres depended very little upon the course of the Sindhu, and their decline began when the flow of water in the Saraswati diminished.

First, a flood in the Saraswati brought about an Aryan migration after the composition of the Rigveda and Yajurveda. Then a decrease in the Saraswati's waters caused a second large migration, before the composition of the Atharvaveda. Spoked chariots are described in the Vedas; they were present neither in West Asia nor in Europe. Indian divine names, crafts, stories, knowledge of horses, music, linguistic elements and modes of thought begin to appear in West Asia, Egypt and Greece. In the second millennium BCE, spoked chariots, Indian divine names, the rivers of India, Rigvedic philosophical ideas, horsemanship, craftsmanship, technology and ancient narratives spread from India towards West Asia and Crete–Greece. In chronological terms, most of the maṇḍalas of the Rigveda had been composed well before the civilisations of Egypt, Sumer–Babylonia, and the Mitanni and Hittites.

The second work in Mayanandji's series is Mantraputra. It presents a philosophy of life grounded in the Rigvedic world.

The Rigveda is divided into ten maṇḍalas (and also into eight aṣṭakas). Mayanand Mishra likewise divides Mantraputra into ten maṇḍalas, following the Rigvedic arrangement. The book's introduction is called Richalok, and it is placed at the end, after the tenth maṇḍala.

In the First Maṇḍala, there is mention of Ṛjiśvā, daughter of Kākṣenī, as well as Shāshvatī, daughter of Ṛturvit. It describes the removal or banishment of a king by the people's assembly and committee, and the election of another king. There is also mention of eyes becoming dark instead of blue, and of this change being attributed to a particular kind of marriage. Repeated disturbances by the dark-complexioned people from the banks of the Vitastā are described, together with the process of intermingling bloodlines on the banks of the Suvāstu. Discussion begins about whether cow sacrifice should be prohibited. Slaves are also mentioned. The fall of Hariyūpiyā and the devastation of its different

towns are narrated, followed by Balbūtha's efforts to reorganise the commercial system of the non-Aryans after its destruction.

In the Second Maṇḍala, the committee deposes a king because he did not undertake a war for cattle, even after cows had been stolen. The consecration of kings increasingly comes to determine succession, and hereditary custom becomes established. Earlier, only after the committee's decision would someone seek support and take up the royal sceptre. The cattle had been abducted by the Anāsa Dasyus. On the banks of the Suvāstu, Krumu, Vitastā and Akkhanī, the study of Śruti and the conduct of war proceed side by side, and the same people perform the duties of Brahmins, Kshatriyas and Vaishyas. On the Saraswati, however, matters take another course: separate villages of seers begin to emerge. All the Anāsa Dasyus are enslaved, and Aryans begin to have children by slave women. The sons of slave women are permitted to build houses in the villages, but the Anāsa Dasyus themselves are not. The narrative says that Aryans wore garments of animal hide, and learned the use of cotton clothing and salt through contact with the Anāsa Dasyus. Both commodities remain under the latter's control. There is also a discussion of compiling the Nighaṇṭu: contact with non-Aryans causes the Aryans to forget their own vocabulary, creating a need to collect it. Gandharva marriage is mentioned as well.

Third Maṇḍala

There is a discussion of the Agniṣṭoma sacrifice and of the sacrifice of goats and buffaloes.

It is said that the great seers enjoyed meat and rice, although bread prepared from wheat, rather than rice, was still more commonly eaten.

Fourth Maṇḍala

The royal consecration sacrifice is discussed, with Ariṣṭanemi acting as the Brahmā, or presiding priest. The grāmaṇī, chariot-maker, smith, charioteer and military commander also participate in the sacrifice.

"In the most ancient age, creation was entirely covered with water!" It is difficult to understand how Mayanand Mishra introduces this idea into the Rigvedic period.

Fifth Maṇḍala

There are accounts of competitions in horsemanship and of a colourful theatrical performance by Anāsa slaves. The king approves its inclusion in the consecration ceremony, and opposition to that decision is also described. Discussion takes place about whether the king should seek the vidatha's permission to grant slaves independent rights of cultivation.

Sixth Maṇḍala

The Mahāvairājī sacrifice is mentioned. Entire Dasyu villages are said to have been enslaved, and their inhabitants are permitted to rear cattle and perform Paṇi-related commercial work. In the episode involving Nagnajit, Brahmins are described as those who chant mantras, Kshatriyas as those who wage battles for cattle, while those who give greater attention to the development of agriculture are the viś—the ordinary people. Mayanandji, however, adds the term Vaishya here as well.

Seventh Maṇḍala

It is only at this stage that the invasion by barbarous white Aryans is mentioned. Like one group of foreign specialists, Mayanandji seems to have recognised the Paiśācī invasion only much later, and then made its people another branch of the Aryans. There is renewed mention of the Aryans burning Hariyūpiyā to the ground. Mohenjo-daro is said first to have been abandoned through terror and then to have been destroyed by an earthquake. Mayanandji now appears confused. Reduced rainfall is also mentioned.

Eighth Maṇḍala

There is mention of villages of seers and indications of male and female slaves within the household. The keeping of bulls is also suggested. The mantra-sons are described as moving into village settlements and becoming members of the viś, or Vaishyas. But as the account advances, Mayanandji becomes increasingly entangled. It is said that before the departure from the shores of the Caspian Sea, Dyaus and Tvaṣṭrī had become minor deities. Brahmins and Kshatriyas are described as not yet having been divided, with everyone free to undertake any occupation. The war between gods and Asuras, the battle on the banks of the Helmand, and the rearing of animals are discussed. Subsequently, the occupations of Brahmins and Kshatriyas begin to diverge. There is then mention of mantra-seeing seers beginning to put the names of deities and their own names into the mantras. As the number of mantras increases, systematic study of Śruti is said to begin.

Ninth Maṇḍala

Markets begin to be organised for exchanging goods. The market has a pottery section, where enslaved artisans display their wares, as well as a section for textiles. Goods made of clay, ivory, copper and shells are mentioned, together with objects for children's amusement, such as figures of elephants and bulls. Salt, grain, timber and blankets are also sold.

Tenth Maṇḍala

The Nāga people are informed of the arrival of white people—the barbarous white Aryans. The Nāgas are said to call their leader a king, and to have moved, in an earlier period, by crawling or creeping towards the Yamuna, displacing the people already living there. The dark people's wooden forts are mentioned, and they too, along with the Nāgas, are called Anāsa. The former, however, are tall, whereas the Nāgas are somewhat shorter. In this maṇḍala references to Shudras and to the Ganga river appear alongside those to slaves. There are signs of cooperation among Aryans, slaves and Shudras.

The introduction entitled Richalok is written at the end. Mantraputra, founded on propositions such as Indra's renouncing the title Asura after the war between gods and Asuras, the movements of the Hittites and Mitanni, and the eastward advance of the Aryans, fails to satisfy all the criteria of historicity.

Had Mayanand Mishra maintained a literary writer's perspective and avoided the gossip disseminated by a section of Western historians, he might have rejected the theory of an Aryan invasion. The Saraswati appears in all the maṇḍalas of the Rigveda in its vast and delightful form. The civilisation of the Sindhu or Saraswati river valley began to end or decline when the Saraswati dried up. The Atharvaveda, too, presents the Saraswati as full of water. The Rigveda does not mention a great flood, whereas the Atharvaveda contains indications in that direction. When the people of Bharata travelled westward, they carried the story of the flood with them. Following the flood, the Bharatas moved eastwards from the Saraswat region towards Kuru-Panchala and the Brahmarshi region.

Had the Saraswati survived, matters would have been different. But the dried-up Saraswati became a dividing line, and for those who advocated the Aryan-invasion theory, crossing that vanished river became impossible.

Even the study of the Indus script has not proved possible without the assistance of Brahmi.

The suspicion that the Aryans came as invaders from the northwest and broke down the forts of the indigenous inhabitants was first expressed in a footnote to Griffith's translation of the Rigveda. The people who lived in those forts were more civilised. In 1947 Wheeler advanced the theory that the region of the newly partitioned Pakistan had been the centre of civilisation and that the Aryan invaders were foreigners. Earlier, the Indian scholar Ramprasad Chanda had already said that the inhabitants of these cities were the Paṇis of the Rigveda. Marshall, however, had proposed in 1931 that the Aryans entered India around 2000 BCE, by which time

Harappā and Mohenjo-daro had already been destroyed. In 1934 Gordon Childe suggested that the Aryans might have been invaders. In 1938 Mackay rejected an invasion of Mohenjo-daro, arguing that it could not be established on the basis of a few skeletons. In 1964 Dales wrote an essay, "The Mythical Massacre of Mohenjo-Daro," ridiculing the story of an invasion. Wheeler then retreated somewhat in 1966, but instead of Mackay's tribal groups he placed the whole responsibility for invasion on the foreign Aryans. He now began to say that an Aryan invasion could not be proved, but that what could not be established was not thereby impossible. Stuart Piggott continued to share Wheeler's prejudice until 1962, describing the Aryans as having arrived from Mitanni. Norman Brown, too, was doubtful about the cultural relationship between the Punjab and the rest of India. Emeneau, the American specialist in Sanskrit and Dravidian languages, wrote that the Indus Valley had never been culturally linked with the rest of India in that way, and that the Aryans who arrived there were closer to Iranian civilisation.

Pargiter, however, demonstrated from the literary tradition in 1922 that there was no evidence of an Aryan invasion of India. He argued that the Aryans had travelled westwards from India and that literary evidence for this movement was available. Langdon likewise held that the Aryans were among India's earliest inhabitants and used an Aryan language and script. Scholars such as Bridget and Raymond Allchin and Colin Renfrew have examined prejudices in the interpretation of ancient Indian history.

Mitanni rulers worshipped Mitra, Varuṇa, Indra and the Nāsatyas. Vedic deities were also worshipped in the Hittite kingdom. Albright and Lambdin likewise acknowledged that an Indo-Aryan language was spoken in southwest Asia two thousand years ago and that its numeral words were Indian.

These people were Indians who travelled outside India after the composition of the Rigveda. Feminine plural forms and the distinctive character of Rigvedic deities are not found elsewhere. The scarcity of Indian goddesses in the Indo-European pantheon is an indication of the later European patriarchal order following the earlier matriarchal order in India.

Now consider the Sumerian flood, which is placed in 3100 BCE. The Indian Kali era is reckoned from 3102 BCE. Therefore the entire Rigveda had been composed before that date.

At the end of the book, in Richalok, Mayanandji writes, among other things, that Indra relinquished the title Asura after the conflict between gods and Asuras. Some Western scholars also seek to diminish the philosophical significance of the Rigveda by saying that the divine pantheon was fully developed in Greece, whereas Rigvedic society was

nomadic and thus possessed no developed pantheon. They also claim that the Rigveda was composed by Western invaders who wandered on horseback. Rigvedic poets knew both early collective ownership and clan society based on blood relationships, but had themselves moved beyond them and begun to establish an order based on individual and family property. Property was centred on men and the family was patriarchal. Yet they had not forgotten the matriarchal order, for they worship and remember the goddesses of the waters in the plural as "āpaḥ mātaraḥ," and likewise always invoke and worship the Maruts collectively as a gaṇa.

Engels then says that the transition from matriarchy to patriarchy in Greece was the greatest revolution of ancient times. That revolution had already taken place in the Rigvedic period. As labour becomes specialised, the role of the gotra in production diminishes while that of the family increases. The sequential development of gaṇa, gotra, kula and family arises from the organisation of collectively owned land. The Rigveda mentions potters, carpenters, blacksmiths and metalwork. In ancient Iran, the form ahura was used as the counterpart of asura, and the Iranians worshipped it. But the influence of the Indian people who worshipped Asuras was confined to Iran and spread no farther. In India the Asuras are wicked, whereas in Iran the devas are wicked. The dignity of the Asura is present throughout the Rigveda: there is no maṇḍala in which one deity or another is not called an Asura. Yet there are also Asuras opposed to the gods, and Indra is invoked to destroy such "adevâḥ asurâḥ," godless Asuras. Like Indra, Agni destroys Asuras, while Indra and Bṛhaspati themselves are both Asuras. Asura was a title of the deities. Alongside gods and Asuras, the Rigveda also presents Asuras as a separate class: Asuras breathed, but the gods did not. The Asuras are more ancient than the gods; thus Varuṇa, as an Asura, is king of both the gods and human beings.

A Paiśācī complexion or skin was never regarded with such delight in India. Even so, advocates of the Aryan-invasion theory should consider this fact by way of example: South Indian Brahmins, Kashmiri Brahmins and Brahmins of Nepal differ not only in skin colour but also in physical appearance. This shows that they were local populations incorporated into the caste order in their respective forms. For such differences of appearance and complexion cannot, on anthropological and scientific grounds, emerge within five hundred or a thousand years. Neither the Europeans living in South America and Africa nor the people described as Negroes and Red Indians living in America, Africa and Europe have changed in complexion within five hundred years. Such differences arise through residence over hundreds of thousands of years, with inhabitants of hot regions becoming dark and those of cold regions fair.

Purohit

Purohit, written in Hindi, is the third volume in the series. It opens with the Dūrvākṣata invocation, which Mayanand Mishra also, for convenience, calls a benediction.

Purohit begins with the Dūrvākṣata benedictory mantra. This is verse 22 of Chapter 22 of the Śukla Yajurveda, extending from "Oṃ ā brahman..." to "naḥ kalpatām." In Mithila the following is also recited at the end of the mantra: "Oṃ mantrārthāḥ siddhayaḥ santu manorathāḥ. Śatrūṇāṃ buddhinaśo'stu mitrāṇām udayas tava. Oṃ dīrghāyur bhava. Oṃ saubhāgyavatī bhava." With the addition of these four pādas, the mantra assumes the form of a blessing.

The Yajurvedic mantra 22.22 is recited throughout India in the manner of a patriotic song.

The Dūrvākṣata Mantra (Śukla Yajurveda, Chapter 22, Verse 22)

आ ब्रह्मन्नित्यस्य प्रजापतिर्ऋषिः। लिंभोक्ता देवताः। स्वराड्उत्कृतिश्छन्दः। षड्जः स्वरः॥

For the mantra beginning "Ā Brahman," Prajāpati is named as the seer; "लिंभोक्ता" is given as the deity; Svarāḍ-Utkṛti as the metre; and Ṣaḍja as the musical note.

आ ब्रह्मन् ब्राह्मणो ब्रह्मवर्चसी जायतामा राष्ट्रे राजन्यः
शुरेऽइषव्योऽतिव्याधी महारथो जायतां दोग्ध्री धेनुर्वोढानड्वानाशुः सप्तिः
पुरन्धिर्योवा जिष्णू रथेष्ठाः सभेयो युवास्य यजमानस्य वीरो जायतां
निकामे-निकामे नः पर्जन्यो वर्षतु फलवत्यो नऽओषधयः पच्यन्तां योगेक्षमो
नः कल्पताम् ॥२२॥

O Brahman, may there arise in the nation a Brahmin radiant with sacred learning, and a courageous ruler, skilled with arrows, capable of overcoming enemies, a mighty chariot-warrior. May there be a milk-giving cow, a burden-bearing ox, a swift horse, a capable woman, victorious chariot-fighters, and an eloquent young hero in the patron's assembly. May Parjanya bring rain whenever we need it; may the plants and healing herbs bear fruit and ripen; and may our well-being and security be assured.

मन्त्रार्थाः सिद्धयः सन्तु पूर्णाः सन्तु मनोरथाः। शत्रूणां बुद्धिनाशोऽस्तु मित्राणामुदयस्तव।

May the purposes of the mantras be fulfilled; may wishes be fully realised. May the intelligence of enemies be destroyed and may your friends prosper.

ॐ दीर्घायुर्भव। ॐ सौभाग्यवती भव।

Oṃ: May you live long. Oṃ: May you be blessed with good fortune.

O Lord, may capable and all-knowing students be born in our country, and soldiers who can destroy the enemy. May the cows of our land yield abundant milk, the oxen be able to carry heavy loads, and the horses run swiftly. May women be capable of leading towns and cities, and young people speak forcefully in assemblies and show the capacity for leadership. May rain fall in our country whenever it is needed, and may medicinal plants and herbs continue to ripen. In this way, may we prosper in every respect. May the intelligence of enemies be destroyed and friends rise to prosperity.

The mantra describes what human beings ought to desire.

It contains the figure of speech known as vācaka-luptopamālaṅkāra, a simile in which the explicit comparative expression is omitted.

Anvaya—Word-by-Word Interpretation

ब्रह्मन् — Brahman, endowed with learning and other virtues.

राष्ट्रे — in the country.

ब्रह्मवर्चसी — possessing the radiance of sacred learning.

आ जायतां — may be born; may arise.

राजन्यः — king.

शुरेऽ — fearless.

इषव्यो — skilled in shooting arrows.

ऽतिव्याधी — one who overcomes or defeats the enemy.

महारथो — a mighty hero commanding a great chariot.

दोग्ध्रीं — fulfilling the desire for milk; giving milk abundantly.

धेनुर्वोढानड्वानाशुः — धेनुः cow or speech; वोढानड्वाः a large, burden-bearing ox; नाशुः /आशुः: swift.

सप्तिः — horse.

पुरंन्धिर्योवा — पुरंन्धिः a woman capable of conducting affairs; र्योवाः woman.

जिष्णू — one who conquers enemies.

रथेष्ठाः — firmly stationed in a chariot.

सभेयो — in an excellent assembly.

युवास्य — youthful; like a young man.

यजमानस्य — in the kingdom of the king.

वीरो — a hero who defeats enemies.

निकामे-निकामे — in undertakings pursued with firm resolve.

नः — our; of us all.

पर्जन्यो — rain-cloud.

वर्षतु — may it rain.

फलवत्यो — fruitful; bearing excellent fruit.

ओषधयः — medicinal herbs.

पच्यन्तां — may they ripen.

योगेक्षमो — the safeguarding of what has been acquired, and the attainment of what has not yet been acquired.

नः — for us all.

कल्पताम् — may it be made possible; may it prove sufficient.

Griffith's translation: O Brahman, may there be in our kingdom Brahmins of sound religious learning; brave rulers, archers, milk-giving cows, swift-running animals, and enterprising women. May Parjanya grant rain when needed; may fruit-bearing trees ripen; may we obtain and preserve our prosperity.

There follows the author's preface, which in Purohit is entitled Viniyoga. Purohit is based on the society of the period of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa.

The Viniyoga discusses the dating of the Early and Later Vedic ages, the age of the Mahābhārata, and related periods. It also considers the emergence of the ideas of renunciation and liberation, the composition of Sūtra literature, the Āraṇyakas, the Upaniṣads, and the Brāhmaṇa texts. There is discussion of the beginnings of the doctrine of status by birth in place of status by action, the emergence of the word Śūdra, the growth of towns, the use of punch-marked coins, the strengthening of industry, and the use of iron. Mayanandji then writes that the Battle of the Ten Kings took place in 1800 BCE, and that a combined group of Bharatas and

Kuśikas–Kassites crossed the Beas from the banks of the Saraswati, passing through the Ilāvṛta mountain region, and established the monarchies of Kosala and Mithila even before the culture of Kuru-Pañcāla had developed.

Purohit is divided into thirteen cantos and ends with an epilogue. The first canto opens in the city of Kāmpilya in Southern Pañcāla. Smoke rising at dusk from the cattle sheds of Atharvaṇapallī is described. The narrative moves forward through Medhā and Kuśabindu. At the hermitage of the seer Gālava, pupils are first made to memorise the Ṛgveda; instruction in agriculture is given only subsequently.

The second canto describes the insult offered to a Brahmin by the foolish son of King Pravāhaṇa Jaibāli, and distinguishes between the first category, the śrotriya Brahmin, and the second, the priestly Brahmin.

In the third canto, the priestly class decides to withdraw from officiating after Ācārya Cākrāyaṇa is insulted. The consequent disruption of the people's daily agnihotra rites, and of agricultural and commercial work undertaken without consultation of auspicious dates, is described.

The fourth canto introduces the Vyāsa narrative and the Bhārata war. Here Mayanandji follows a Western perspective. Mayanand Mishra makes the casual assertion that the Jaya poem was given the form of the narrative of the Bhārata war.

In the fifth canto, Vaiśyas are described as abandoning the upanayana initiation, whereas both sons and daughters among Kṣatriyas still undergo it. Vaiśya girls are increasingly excluded from education, while Brahmin girls receive instruction from their fathers in addition to what is provided at the gurukula. Brahmins have little time left after their priestly duties.

The sixth canto discusses the refusal of Brahmin priests to recognise the Atharvaveda.

The seventh canto describes instruction in Atharvavedic rites at Atharvaṇapallī and the refusal of first-rank Brahmins to visit that settlement.

The eighth canto describes chariot-racing, horsemanship, wrestling, swordplay, target-shooting, and extraordinary forms of mimicry at the Indra festival, including performances by the inhabitants of Vyāsapallī. At Vyāsapallī, the vrātya Karuṣa recounts the tale of the Bhārata war. The account also states that, long before that war, the mixed peoples of the Bharatas, Tritsus, Kivis and Sṛñjayas in Āryāvarta proudly called themselves Sūdras, in memory of the Sumerian Ziusudra, and that the designation Śūdra derived from this usage.

The ninth canto discusses the distinction introduced when weavers began giving garments intended for women a distinctive border; previously there had been no such distinction. It also describes differences between Atharvan and sacrificial Brahmins.

The tenth canto speaks of the worship of Śiśnadeva by non-Aryans and the Atharvan priests' ignorance of that practice. It is said that alphabetic writing is used in Vyāsapallī, while in Ācārya Gālava's hermitage of oral learning nothing may be seen beyond numerical notation.

In the eleventh canto, although discussion of daṇḍanīti—the principles of punishment and government—is prohibited in Gālava's hermitage, it takes place at the request of councillors from Southern Pañcāla. King Śilājita is said to offer the royal office to the chief priest.

The twelfth canto states that after the Bhārata war the custom of niyoga lost acceptance and ceased. It also discusses the assimilation of Śiśnadeva into Śivadeva.

The thirteenth canto describes the coronation celebrations of King Kraivya. In the Dūrvākṣata mantra,

"ॐ मंत्रार्था सिद्धयः संतु मनोरथाः। शत्रूणां बुद्धिनाशोऽस्तु मित्राणामुदयस्तव" and the blessing "dīrghāyur bhava" are combined with Śukla Yajurveda 22.22. The account describes singing it while holding dūrvā grass and unhusked rice, with particular attention to rhythm, tempo, and pauses. Mayanandji also provides a translation inspired by Griffith's:

May there arise throughout the world, everywhere, Brahmins whose brilliance in learning establishes its supremacy, and patron kingdoms possessing brave, healthy, mighty chariot-warriors skilled in archery. May there be cows yielding ever more milk, powerful bulls, spirited horses, beautiful and virtuous young women, and heroic sons eager for victory. Whenever we wish, may Parjanya bring rain; may vegetation flourish, medicinal plants bear fruit, and every living creature be content in the security of its well-being. May the king live a hundred years.

For the coronation of King Kraivya, the mantra is recited while holding akṣata, aravā rice, vrīhi grain, and blades of dūrvā grass. At its conclusion these are scattered over the king; curd is then taken from a small pot and used to place a tilaka on his forehead. Mayanandji writes in this passage that the mantra known in Mithila as Dūrvākṣata was composed by Yājñavalkya for the Vājasaneyi Saṃhitā. He adds that it subsequently came to be used in Mithila as a benediction for a boy at his upanayana and for bride and groom at their wedding.

Purohit concludes with an epilogue. It describes the Aryanisation of non-Aryan villages along the road to Kāśī and the performance of the vrātyastoma sacrifice. It discusses the Śiśnadevas, the story of Śunaḥśepa, the beginning of the tradition of telling the Bhārata narrative, and the aversion towards Aryan religion among the people of Magadha.

Mayanandji seems to follow Western scholars even in addressing the problems of the Mahābhārata. Professor Weber was the first to advance the theory that there was a Jaya Saṃhitā of 8,800 verses and that the original epic contained only the four books of war—Bhīṣma, Droṇa, Karṇa, and Śalya—among its eighteen books. He based this theory on a single verse:

अष्टौश्लोक सहस्राणि… अहं वेद्मि शुको वेत्ति सञ्जयो वेत्ति वा न वा

"Eight thousand verses … I know them; Śuka knows them; whether Sañjaya knows them or not …"

Sañjaya, Vyāsa and Śuka were each able to remember only 8,800 verses of the Bhārata. That means the Bhārata was so extensive that no one of them could memorise it in its entirety; from this perspective the work written by Vyāsa could never have contained fewer than 26,400 verses. The term Jaya Saṃhitā was used for both the Bhārata and the Mahābhārata. The books of war—the four of the eighteen books devoted to Bhīṣma, Droṇa, Karṇa, and Śalya—are so closely bound to the other books that the succeeding book cannot be understood without reading what precedes it. The war of the Iliad lasted ten years, but the Iliad confines itself to the siege of Troy. The Mahābhārata, by contrast, begins long before the causes that led to its eighteen-day war. The Bhīṣma Parva is the sixth book, the Droṇa Parva the seventh, the Karṇa Parva the eighth, and the Śalya Parva the ninth. Nine further books follow them.

The Mahābhārata was recited at many sittings, and it was therefore natural for passages already heard to be recalled repeatedly. To infer from these repetitions that they are interpolations would be absurd. Western scholars similarly consider the Gītā an interpolation, because in approaching Indian culture, literature, and art with a foreign mentality they commit errors. Foreign scholars find it difficult to accept that the Mahābhārata, although so ancient, is so vast that the Iliad seems insignificant beside it. Weber's false interpretation of a single verse thus gave rise to the notion of the Jaya Saṃhitā. Without justification, the development of the epic was represented as passing through three stages: Jaya Saṃhitā, Bhārata, and Mahābhārata. Even in its smallest form, the Mahābhārata contained no fewer than 24,600 verses, and the designation Jaya Saṃhitā referred collectively to the Bhārata and the Mahābhārata.

Strīdhan

This book is the final link in Mayanand Mishra's exploration of historical consciousness. Following the prehistoric Prathamam Śailaputrī Ca, the Rigvedic Mantraputra, and the later-Vedic Purohit, this Hindi novel is situated in the age of the Sūtras and Smṛtis. It is set in Mithila. The book begins with Mayanandji's preface, entitled Pṛṣṭhabhūmi ("Background") in this volume. After considering the chronology of the Rāmāyaṇa and Mahābhārata, he speaks of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa as the historians' sole documentary evidence.

Mithila's earliest name was Videha, first mentioned in the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa. Mayanandji says that the book offers a detailed description of the movements of trading caravans, or sārthas.

The work has two chapters, First and Second, followed by an epilogue. The first chapter contains nine sessions, numbered one to nine; the second contains eight cantos, numbered one to eight.

First Chapter

First Session

There is an account of Sṛñjaya's begging for alms as a form of religious repentance and of his observance of a severe vow continuously for six months because he had abandoned his wife.

The expression "द्वितीय वर" (dvitīya vara) is also discussed.

Second Session

Karāla Janaka, the eldest son of King Bahulāśva Janaka, ascends the throne in accordance with the hereditary traditions of the ruling dynasty.

Third Session

Here we see a conflict between the old and the new. At one point Vāruṇī says that since her revered father duly performed her upanayana, and in her period of brahmacarya she received instruction in the Śruti according to ancient custom, she now wishes, as a respectable young woman, to choose her own husband and marry him.

Fourth Session

There are murmurs of rebellion against Karāla Janaka. The just and public-spirited welfare measures taken during the reigns of Kṛti Janaka and Bahulāśva Janaka are recalled, as is Mithila's territorial expansion from the time of Sīradhvaja Janaka. At his death, Bahulāśva warned his son Karāla not to neglect or insult the revered Ācārya Vareṇya of the

Agrāmātya division. Yet in time Karāla Janaka did just that. Ācārya Vareṇya and his group migrated from Mithila.

Fifth Session

The formalities of respectful greeting, blessing, and inquiries after well-being are described, and women's property, or strīdhan, enters the conversation. There is also the account that Vaiśālī had for a time been under Kosala and was under Mithila during the Bhārata war. King Karāla Janaka is said to have broken the customary exemption from taxation for five springs after forestland had been brought under cultivation.

Sixth Session

The people of Pañcāla are said to regard Vāsudeva Kṛṣṇa, leader of the Andhakas and Vṛṣṇis, as the hero of the Jaya poem. The Western scholars' discarded intellectual fare concerning the Jaya and Bhārata poems has still not departed from Mayanandji's mind. Once again he repeats the false claim that the sage Vaiśampāyana added numerous verses to Vyāsa's Jaya poem and transformed it into the extensive Bhārata. Kṛṣṇa Dvaipāyana Vyāsa is identified as the author of Jaya. The same point is repeated as though it were some extraordinary discovery.

There is further discussion of the development of divinity and of the sudden drying-up of the Saraswati River.

The beginning of image worship of Saraswati and the Mother Goddess is also discussed.

Seventh Session

Saraswati is made into a Mother Goddess, and the worship of an imagined image of her is described. The custom in Mithila of a wife not uttering her husband's name is also mentioned.

Eighth Session

The king's tyranny has reached its height. Apūrvā is compelled to renounce domestic life and relinquish her strīdhan as well.

Ninth Session

More than a hundred village headmen assemble in conference.

There is discussion of the five-spring tax exemption and of the possible migration of forest-dwellers and Śūdras if it is withdrawn. After Sīradhvaja Janaka, the ritual seizure of cows had survived merely as a custom following coronation. Karāla, however, is described as refusing to return the cattle belonging to his clansman Śoṇabhadra. Karāla also dismisses the chief priest during his reign. A young medical practitioner, the student

Kṛtārtha, is summoned to treat the princess; Vāruṇī, the princess's friend and the daughter of Ācārya Kṛta, is summoned too. She goes with the younger student, but Karāla forcibly closes the door of his chamber and contracts a gāndharva marriage with her. A popular rebellion breaks out, and the king escapes on horseback. With this, the ninth and final session of the first chapter comes to an end.

Second Chapter

First Canto

The Sita River is mentioned. Varuṇa asks Vāruṇī to accompany the sārthavāha caravan merchants to the Aṅga region. He also says that the work of Aryanising Aṅga is still incomplete.

Second Canto

Third Canto

In Aṅga, it is said, aravā rice is not made directly from paddy. Rather, paddy is first boiled and dried, then pounded in a ḍhekī, and the resulting grain is called rice, whereas vrīhi is called paddy. The older class of merchant-guild leaders, the twice-born Vaiśyas, and the newer, non-twice-born Vaiśyas are also discussed.

Fourth Canto

The repeated references to Aryanisation demonstrate the influence of Western scholarship upon Mayanandji. Both "Aryan" and "Dravidian," I contend, were terms introduced in India by Westerners for their own vested interests. The development of Kosala and Videha, and the entire history of the evolution of divinity, are presented here. Mithila's familiar dish of curd and flattened rice is also mentioned.

Fifth Canto

Eating a single meal during the day and drinking milk at night were customs in both Mithila and Pañcāla. There were minor differences in ways of life between the so-called Aryans and the local inhabitants, and Mayanandji calls the bridging of these differences "Aryanisation"!

Sixth Canto

The houses of Aṅga are described as standing apart from one another, rather than close together as in the Aryan villages. Their inhabitants wear short garments and animal skins. The suggestion of human sacrifice among forest peoples and the exchange of language with expelled forest-dwellers are, in my view, further ideas that Mayanandji has absorbed under Western influence.

There is discussion of establishing marketplaces, from which towns might later develop.

Seventh Canto

Parboiled rice is said to be more digestible and is therefore prescribed as suitable food for the sick. The need for artisans is discussed: blacksmiths to make iron ploughshares, carpenters for ploughs, and potters for vessels and utensils, together with the provision of residential land and food for them.

Eighth Canto

Once agriculture produces a surplus, people can exchange grain for other goods, and bullock carts can transport these goods. There is also an account of the bhūdevas arranging a sacrifice lasting one month. During the teaching of language, Brāhmaṇagāma becomes Bābhanagāma and Vanagrāma becomes Vanagāma through changes in pronunciation. Returning after teaching the language, Vāruṇī is attacked with an arrow and subsequently dies.

Epilogue

By the arrival of the second spring, the establishment of a republican form of government in Mithila has become secure. Vaiśālī and Mithila begin discussions aimed at joining in a republican association. In the capital at Sitagrāma, Mithila's earlier eastward territorial expansion is recalled. Between the capital Sitagrāma and Jitagrāma in eastern Mithila stood a vast forest. It was cleared and removed through the combined efforts of Brāhmaṇagrāma and Trigrāma.

A point concerning linguistics: certain distinctive Prakrit words, sounds, suffixes, and sentence constructions are found in Rigvedic hymns. Pāṇini established Sanskrit as a standard language, freed from regional particularities. In Karnataka, water is called nīru, while in northern India it is called jal; both forms, according to this discussion, are found in Sanskrit. In creating a language free from regional peculiarities, Pāṇini did not disregard any region. Instead, he drew upon the vocabularies of all regions and eliminated differences of pronunciation. Many Prakrit words were adopted into Sanskrit after phonetic modification, and this subsequently gave rise to the belief that the Prakrit words were tadbhavas, or derivative forms. This is why Sanskrit itself does not appear to possess tadbhava vocabulary. Similarly, Apabhraṃśa and Prakrit were languages of people who travelled throughout the country.

The development of the pantheon in India is linked to ideas concerning water. As long as the universe remains unmanifest, it is darkness and space; when it becomes manifest, it takes the form of water. Both space and water

are elements in Indian thought. Mayanandji's depiction of the development of image worship is a simplification. The method of linguistic dissemination that he portrays in Strīdhan is likewise an excessive simplification.

The continuity of tradition through listening and oral recitation is evident in literature; in the Mahābhārata this can be seen repeatedly in many places. It is therefore not possible to declare several of its books interpolations merely on that account. An examination of the Vedic Prātiśākhyas would show that such an oral tradition was not possible in the presence of an established writing tradition; by the time of the Mahābhārata, however, the injunctions had become more rigid. The Mahābhārata states:

वेदविक्रयिणश्चैव वेदानांचैवदूषकः।

"Those who sell the Vedas and those who corrupt the Vedas ..."

वेदानांलेखकश्चैव तेवै निरयगामिनः॥

"... and those who write down the Vedas—all such people go to hell."

(Those who sell the Vedas, misinterpret them, or write them down are all destined for hell.)

The Karāla Episode: The Arthaśāstra describes Karāla Janaka's misdeeds as follows:

(१.६ विनयाधिकारिके प्रथमाधिकरणे षडोऽध्यायः इन्द्रियजये अरिषड्वर्गत्याग): तद्विरुद्धवृत्तिरवश्येन्द्रियश्चातुरन्तोऽपि राजा सद्यो विनश्यति- यथा
दाण्डक्यो नाम भोजः कामाद् ब्राह्मण कन्यायमभिमन्यमानः सबन्धराष्ट्रोविननाश करालश्च वैदेहः,...।

(Arthaśāstra 1.6, on the conquest of the senses and abandonment of the six inner enemies): A king who acts contrary to this discipline, unable to restrain his senses, is destroyed at once even if he rules the four quarters. Thus Daṇḍakya Bhoja, driven by desire for a Brahmin girl, perished along with his relatives and kingdom; likewise Karāla of Videha ...

The Jayamaṅgala commentary of the monk Prabhamati adds that while Karāla was looking towards a crowd at the Yogeśvara pilgrimage site, he noticed a beautiful Brahmin woman and forcibly took her to his kingdom. The Brahmin went to Karāla's capital and, weeping in anger, asked why the earth did not split open in a land ruled by such a wicked king. The earth opened, and Karāla sank into it and died with his family.

The abduction of a Brahmin woman as the cause of Karāla's downfall is mentioned in Aśvaghoṣa's Buddhacarita as well as in Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra. The Dīpavaṃsa, however, describes Karāla Janaka's son and grandson as kings after him. The Brāhmaṇa texts represent Videha as a monarchy, whereas Buddhist texts describe it as a republic in which the king is chosen by a council; this difference of perspective explains the disagreement.

Thus Mayanand Mishra's historical journey has introduced a great many assertions that cannot be supported by reasoning.

Supplementary Discussion

I have reviewed Mayanand's historical consciousness on the basis of śruti, tradition, reasoning, and linguistics. The review seeks to avoid a mode of writing Indian history built out of the leftovers of Western scholars' intellectual feast, and to prevent the perspective of Central Asia and Europe from exerting even the slightest influence upon the assessment.

1. Agnā. The novel begins in 2000 BCE. It opens with an account of human beings living in caves. Bā is the strongest man in one group. An ancestral Bā, too, was powerful—the father of so many children. The ancestral Bā had invented a smaller stone and a larger one. The group leader was called am. Bā was also the name of an animal with a terrible smell. The importance of the hand increased, as did the distance between human beings and trees. From their ancestors, they knew that snakes were not to be killed and eaten. The ancient divinities were, first, the tree; second, the serpent; and third, the river. Bā had been fathering children by Ambā. A new axe and a new spinning implement were invented. People discovered that wild animals fled on hearing the sounds “aḥ,” “āḥ,” “ag,” and “agg.” The women bore children and enlarged the population. The first woman to receive an individual name was Agnā. Her male companion was Agg. Agnā became the leader of the group, and under her leadership it moved northward. The author then writes that the earth originated approximately two billion years ago, which he considers entirely correct. At

one point in ritual usage one finds the formulation "ब्राह्मणे द्वितीये परार्धे श्री स्वेतवाराह कल्पे वैवस्वत मन्वंतरे अष्ठाविंशतितमे कलियुगे प्रथम चरणे"; a calculation based on this produces an age of 1,97,29,49,032 years for the earth. The radioactive method, he maintains, yields the same answer. Until the seventeenth century in Europe, the earth was considered four thousand years old; Iranian scholars placed its origin twelve hundred years in the past. Both views appear ridiculous when judged scientifically.

The second part begins with "Agnā–Śailā," dated 10,000 BCE. Here Mayanand Mishra depicts the beginnings of language, portraying particularly well the connection between the language of signs and sound. He also depicts the passage from a mobile to a settled life. The next chapter, "Śailā–Karālī," begins 7,500 years ago. It discusses cattle-rearing and the considerable increase in the number of cows. Everyone was a herdsman, wearing animal skins and carrying stone weapons at the waist. There were sheep, goats, pigs, and several other domesticated species. Grass ropes, the trident, and the serpent-deity are mentioned. Bā now comes to be called Ojā, while the group leader is named Śailā Karālī. As livestock increased, the theft of livestock also began. Meetings started taking place beneath the peepal tree. Karālī acquired the name Ambā.

The chapter "Maheṣ–Pārvatī" then begins, four to five thousand years ago. Rice cultivation commenced. When Pārvatī arrived, red earth was placed upon her forehead in accordance with local custom. Her son was named Gaṇeṣ. Previously children were not individually identified in this manner.

"Gaṇeṣ" begins four thousand years ago. It introduces changes in relations between women and men, and the beginnings of a patrilineal order. The procurement and consumption of salt commenced; the group that brought salt came to be called Nonī. The cultivation of barley and wheat and the milking of cows also began. So did the domestication of elephants and exchange through barter. People began offering water and leaves to the phallic deity. Barley was pounded and ground into meal; wheat was crushed, mixed with water, and cooked over fire. One distinct group kept birds. Funeral rites and lamentation for the dead began, as did writing.

"Har" is presented as beginning in 3500 BCE. Salt trading and the construction of better-shaped boats began. The unit called *pailī* was conceived for measurement. The plough began to be used together with bullocks. People started digging wells, spreading their settlements horizontally as well as lengthwise, and building houses. Groups of people

with dark, fair, and copper-coloured complexions arrived at different times.

"Harkisan" begins 3,400 years ago. With agricultural development, the tendency towards permanent residence grew, and the structure of the family became clearer. Expanding agriculture increased the need for commerce. Woollen clothing, grinding mills, houses with walls, and well-enclosures began to be made.

The "Kisan" chapter begins in 3300 BCE. The sale of labour began. Agricultural development gathered momentum with the beginnings of irrigation. Geographical knowledge encouraged commerce, and the practice of wearing ornaments became more widespread.

"Harappā: Mohangāv" is set 3,200 years ago. A group working in wood is offered as an example of the sale of labour. Ornamentation became more prevalent. Bead necklaces and the potter's wheel appear, and class divisions begin to emerge in society.

"Gaṇeṣak Śrīgaṇeṣ" begins in 3100 BCE. The author discusses the building of Harappā by people arriving from the southern region. Mohenjo-daro, Lothal, and Chanhudaro developed into commercial centres. Writing, the cart with a wooden framework, and sculptural art were invented, while markets for barter began to be held. The Mesopotamian flood and the arrival of Sumerians and Asuras are also discussed.

"Kishn" begins in 3000 BCE. Foreign trade commenced, copper was discovered, and agricultural slavery also began. Raised mounds were constructed as protection against floods.

"Kishn Maṇḍal" begins in the period of 2400 BCE. The chapter discusses a shortage of rain and the fear created among the people by reports of Aryan movement eastward.

"Maṇḍal: Maṇḍalī" begins in 2200 BCE. In response both to the arrival of Aryans and to inadequate rainfall, Lothal began to develop as an alternative centre.

"Decline: Purandara" opens in 2000 BCE. With an account of an Aryan king destroying fortified settlements and the great centre of Harappā, Mayanandji concludes his first book, *Prathamam Śailaputrī Ca.* Constructed on theories that Aryans called Harappā Hariyūpiyā and that they came from outside, among others, this novel claims the status of a historical novel. It discusses a historical narrative extending from 20,000 BCE to 1800 BCE. Yet much of it does not appear convincing when considered in relation to independent historical thought and newer research.

The narrative that began with Agnā had inspired considerable hope. In the first chapter the author writes that the earth originated approximately two billion years ago and treats this as entirely correct. A ritual formulation reads "ब्राह्मणे द्वितीये परार्धे श्री स्वेतवाराह कल्पे वैवस्वत मन्वंतरे अष्टाविंशतितमे कलियुगे प्रथम चरणे"; a calculation on its basis produces 1,97,29,49,032 years as the earth's age. The radioactive method, he writes, also produces the same answer. It is estimated, in the argument presented here, that 1.67 parts of uranium change into lead over 10,00,00,000 years. The quantity of lead differs among rocks and rock formations. Such calculation is then taken to show the existence of radioactive substances 1,50,00,00,000 years ago; by this reckoning, no rock can be older than 2,00,00,00,000 years. Up to the seventeenth century Europe considered the earth four thousand years old, while Iranian scholars placed its origin twelve hundred years ago. In his first chapter the novelist rejects such Western scholarship, but by the end he has fallen under the influence of the Western prejudice expressed in the claim that the Aryans called Harappā Hariyūpiyā. He could not escape the leftovers of Western scholars' feast and subject the tradition of śruti to rational scrutiny. Thus, on the following grounds, *Prathamam Śailaputrī Ca* failed to give its historical narrative a satisfactory literary form:

> Archaeological, linguistic, and literary evidence, I argue, supports the view that Aryans were indigenous to India. Max Müller named the Aryan language family, while the missionary Robert Caldwell named the Dravidian family. The theory of an Aryan invasion arose from a footnote in Griffith's translation of the *Rigveda*. These labels were originally supplied by foreign scholars, who may have had purposes of their own.
>
> Voiced aspirates are characteristic of Rigvedic and Indian-language phonetics, not of Iranian or European languages. The civilisation between the Saraswatī and Sindhu rivers was, in this interpretation, Aryan

civilisation. The Bharatas, Purus, and other groups living beside the Saraswatī composed the *Rigveda*. After a catastrophic flood on the Saraswatī, that civilisation moved away from the Saraswat region to Kuru-Pañcāla and Brahmarṣi-deśa, or Madhyadeśa. The Bharatas then lost their historical prominence. It is also possible, the argument suggests, that descendants of the Aryan people built the cities of Mohenjo-daro and Harappā after this inundation. Of the eight hundred Harappan sites, more than 530 lay along the course of the vanished Saraswatī. These centres depended comparatively little on the Sindhu, and their decline began when water flow in the Saraswatī diminished.

The first maṇḍala discusses Ṛjiśvā, daughter of Kākṣasenī, and Śāśvatī, daughter of Ṛturvit. It mentions a king's removal or exile by the people's assembly and committee, and the election of another king. It also discusses a change in eye colour from blue to dark, attributed to particular marriage practices; continual disturbances by groups called Kṛṣṇa along the Vitastā; and the mingling of blood on the Suvāstu. The possibility of prohibiting the *gomedha*, or bovine sacrifice, began to be debated. Slaves are mentioned. Following the fall of Hariyūpiyā and the abandonment of its towns, Balbūtha is said to have reorganised the devastated commercial arrangements of the non-Aryans.

The Mahāvairājī sacrifice is mentioned, as is the enslavement of an entire *dasyu* village, whose people could nevertheless undertake animal husbandry and trade as *paṇis*. In connection with Nagnajit, the author speaks of Brahmins who chanted mantras, Kṣatriyas who fought *gaviṣṭi* battles, and the *viś*, the ordinary people concerned principally with agricultural development. Here, however, Mayanandji also inserts the term "Vaiśya."

Only now does the narrative introduce the invasion of the "barbarian white Aryans." Apparently, like a section of foreign specialists, Mayanandji recognised what he calls this demonic assault only belatedly, and then made its perpetrators another branch of the Aryans. Once again we are told that Aryans burnt and destroyed Hariyūpiyā. Mohenjo-daro was abandoned through terror and then destroyed still further by an earthquake. Mayanandji seems confused at this point. A decline in rainfall is also mentioned.

The village of sages, *Ṛṣigrāma*, is described. There are indications of male and female slaves within households and of bull-rearing. The mantra-son's move to a village and his becoming *viś* or Vaiśya are also discussed. But as the narrative goes on, Mayanandji becomes increasingly entangled. Before the departure from the shores of the Caspian Sea, Dyaus and Tvaṣṭrī are said to have become subordinate divinities. A stage without divisions between Brahmin and Kṣatriya is described, when everyone was free to

undertake any occupation. The Deva–Asura conflict, fighting on the banks of the Helmand, and pastoralism are discussed. Subsequently, Brahmin and Kṣatriya occupations began to diverge. Later, mantra-seeing sages began placing their own names and those of the gods in their hymns. The growing number of mantras led to the systematic practice of oral recitation and memorisation.

At the end appears a preface entitled "Ṛcāloka." *Mantraputra*, constructed around propositions that Indra abandoned the title Asura after the Deva–Asura conflict, that the Hittites and Mitanni moved, and that Aryans advanced eastward, fails to meet every criterion of historical authenticity.

The first suggestion that Aryan invaders came from the northwest and demolished the fortifications of an indigenous population, whose fortified inhabitants were more civilised, appeared in a footnote to Griffith's translation of the *Rigveda*. In 1947 Wheeler propounded the theory that the territory of partitioned Pakistan had been the centre of civilisation and that the Aryan attackers were foreigners. Earlier, the Indian scholar Ram Prasad Chanda had said that the people inhabiting these cities were the *paṇis* of the *Rigveda*. Marshall, however, had proposed in 1931 that Aryans entered India in 2000 BCE, by which time Harappā and Mohenjo-daro had already been destroyed. In 1934 Gordon Childe suggested that Aryans might possibly have been invaders. In 1938 Mackay rejected an invasion of Mohenjo-daro, since a handful of skeletons could not establish it. In 1964 Dales wrote "The Mythical Massacre at Mohenjo-daro," ridiculing the invasion legend. Wheeler subsequently retreated somewhat in 1966 but transferred the whole responsibility for an invasion from Mackay's tribal groups to Aryans from outside. He now said that an Aryan invasion could not be proved; nevertheless, it was not impossible merely because it could not be demonstrated. Stuart Piggott maintained this prejudice alongside Wheeler up to 1962. Piggott said that the Aryans had come from the Mitanni. Norman Brown also doubted the cultural relationship between Punjab and the rest of India. Emeneau, the American specialist in Sanskrit and Dravidian languages, wrote that the Indus Valley had never been culturally connected with the rest of India in quite that way, and that the Aryans who arrived there were closer to Iranian civilisation.

Engels, at this point, says that in Greece the transition from matriarchy to patriarchy was the greatest revolution of antiquity. This revolution, the discussion contends, had already taken place in the Rigvedic age. With the specialisation of labour, the role of the *gotra* in production diminished and that of the family increased. The successive development of *gaṇa*, *gotra*, *kula*, and household was related to the organisation of land held collectively. The *Rigveda* mentions potters, carpenters, blacksmiths, and

metalworking. Ancient Iranian used *ahura* as the counterpart of *asura*. The Iranians worshipped Ahura, but the influence of Indian Asura-worshippers remained confined to Iran and did not spread further. In India the Asuras became evil, whereas in Iran the *daēvas* became evil. Throughout the *Rigveda*, however, the Asura possesses dignity: there is no maṇḍala in which one deity or another is not called Asura. Other Asuras opposed the gods, and Indra was invoked to destroy these *adevās asurās*, godless Asuras. Like Indra, Agni destroyed Asuras, although both Indra and Bṛhaspati themselves bore the title Asura. *Asura* was an epithet of divinity. Yet the *Rigveda* also treated Asuras as a separate class in relation to the Devas: Asuras breathed, whereas Devas did not. Asuras were older than Devas; hence Varuṇa, an Asura, was king of both gods and humans.

O Lord, may capable and all-knowing students arise in our land, and soldiers able to destroy the enemy. May our cows give abundant milk, our bullocks be able to bear heavy loads, and our horses run swiftly. May women be capable of leading our towns, and young people of giving vigorous speeches and exercising leadership in the assembly. May rain fall in our country when it is needed, and medicinal plants and herbs always reach maturity. Thus may every kind of welfare be ours. May the enemy's intelligence be destroyed and our friends prosper.

The passage contains the figure of speech *vācaka-luptopamālaṅkāra*, a simile in which the explicit marker of comparison is absent.

धे॒नुर्वो॑ढा॑न॒ड्वान्॒आ॒शुः धे॒नु-गौ वा वाणी र्वो॑ढा॑न॒ड्वा-पैघ बड़द न्॒आ॒शुः-आ॒शुः-त्वरित

Dhenu means cow (or speech); *anaḍvān* denotes a great bullock; *āśu* means swift. The original accent-marked forms and explanatory wording are retained above.

स॒प्ति॒ः-घोड़ा

Saptīḥ—horse.

Griffith's translation: "O Brahman, may the Brahmins of my realm be learned in sacred knowledge, the Kṣatriyas heroic and skilled in archery; may there be milch cows, swift-running animals, and enterprising women. May Parjanya send rain when needed, may fruit-bearing trees ripen, and may we acquire and preserve prosperity."

In the section on ritual application (*viniyoga*), there is discussion of how to date the early and later Vedic ages and the period of the *Mahābhārata*. The introduction of renunciation and the idea of *mokṣa*, the composition of Sūtra literature, Āraṇyakas, Upaniṣads, and Brāhmaṇa texts are addressed. So are the beginning of the theory of status by birth instead of action (*janmanā* rather than *karmaṇā*), the appearance of the term Śūdra, the consolidation of towns, punch-marked coinage, industry, and the use

of iron. Mayanandji then writes that the Battle of the Ten Kings took place in 1800 BCE, that a combined group of Bharatas and Kuśika–Kassites crossed the Beas from the Saraswatī, traversed the mountainous Ilāvṛta region, and had established the monarchy of Kosala and Mithila before the development of Kuru–Pañcāla culture.

Purohit is divided into thirteen cantos and ends with an epilogue. Its first canto opens in Kāmpilya, the city of southern Pañcāla. The smoke rising at dusk from the cattle-shed of Atharvaṇapallī is described. The story advances through Medhā and Kuśabindu. At the hermitage of the sage Gālava, pupils first memorise the *Rigveda* and only subsequently receive agricultural instruction.

In the fifth canto, Vaiśyas are said to have abandoned the *upanayana* initiation, while both Kṣatriya sons and daughters still underwent it. Vaiśya girls were being deprived of education, whereas Brahmin girls studied with their fathers as well as in a *gurukula*. The priestly work of Brahmins left them little spare time.

In the eighth canto, the Indra festival includes chariot races, riding competitions, wrestling, swordsmanship, target-shooting, and extraordinary mimicry, including performances by the people of Vyāsapallī. There a *vrātya* named Karuṣ narrates the story of the Bhārata war. The account claims that long before that war, a mixed population of Bharatas, Tṛtsus, Kivis, and Sṛñjayas in Āryāvarta began calling themselves Śūdras, in proud remembrance of the Sumerian Ziusudra, even before the emergence of the monarchies of Kosala and Mithila and the culture of Kuru–Pañcāla.

The text describes a blessing that combines “ॐ मंत्रार्था सिद्धयः संतु मनोरथाः। शत्रूणां बुद्धिनाशोऽस्तु मित्राणामुदयस्तव” (“Oṃ, may the intentions of the mantra and cherished wishes be fulfilled; may the intelligence of your enemies perish and your friends prosper”) and *dīrghāyur bhava* (“May you live long”) with the mantra of the White *Yajurveda*, 22.22. Sacred *dūrvā* grass and unbroken rice grains (*akṣata*) are used, and the verses are sung with specific rhythm, movement, and pauses. Mayanandji also gives a translation inspired by Griffith's rendering.

अष्टौश्लोक सहस्राणि..... अहं वेद्मि शुको वेत्ति सञ्जयो वेत्ति वा न वा

“Eight thousand verses … I know, Śuka knows, and Sañjaya may or may not know.”

Sañjaya, Vyāsa, and Śuka, it is said, each remembered only 8,800 verses of the *Bhārata*. This means the *Bhārata* was so extensive that no single one of them could remember it in its entirety; on that reading the work

composed by Vyāsa could never have contained fewer than 26,400 verses. The *Jaya Saṃhitā* is used as a name both for the *Bhārata* and for the *Mahābhārata*. The war books—four of the eighteen books, namely the Bhīṣma, Droṇa, Karṇa, and Śalya Parvans—are so closely connected with the other books that without reading the preceding books one cannot understand what follows. The war of the *Iliad* lasted ten years, yet the poem concerns itself only with the siege of Troy. The *Mahābhārata*, by contrast, begins much earlier with the causes of its eighteen-day war. The Bhīṣma Parvan is the sixth book, Droṇa the seventh, Karṇa the eighth, and Śalya the ninth; nine further books follow.

This work is the final link in Mayanand Babu's conception of history. After the prehistoric *Prathamam Śailaputrī Ca*, the Rigvedic *Mantraputra*, and the later-Vedic *Purohit*, comes a work situated in the age of Sūtra and Smṛti literature. Written in Hindi, the novel concerns Mithila. It opens with a preface by Mayanandji entitled "Background" (*Pṛṣṭhabhūmi*). After calculating the dates of the *Rāmāyaṇa* and *Mahābhārata*, he discusses the *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* as what he calls the historians' sole evidence.

There are descriptions of formal obeisance, blessings, and enquiries after well-being, while the topic of women's property (*strīdhan*) arises in conversation. It is also said that Vaiśālī was under Kosala for a time, but came under Mithila during the Bhārata war. King Karāla Janaka is described as overturning the convention that newly reclaimed forest land should remain free of taxation for five years.

The Pañcāla people are said to regard Vāsudeva Kṛṣṇa, the Andhaka–Vṛṣṇi leader, as the hero of the *Jaya* poem. Mayanandji cannot free his mind from what I consider the Western leftovers concerning *Jaya* and *Bhārata*: the false assertion recurs that the sage Vaiśampāyana added numerous verses to Vyāsa's *Jaya* to make the massive *Bhārata*. Kṛṣṇa Dvaipāyana Vyāsa is named as the author of *Jaya*, and the claim is repeated as though it possessed special evidentiary force.

The king's tyranny reaches its height. Apūrvā is compelled to renounce household life and relinquish her *strīdhan* as well.

The exemption from tax for five springs and the possible consequent migration of forest-dwellers and Śūdras are discussed. After Sīradhvaja Janaka, cattle-raiding is said to have become merely a ceremonial custom following a royal consecration. Karāla, however, does not return the cattle of his fellow-clansman Śoṇabhadra. He removes the chief priest from his position. A young doctor, the student Kṛtārtha, is summoned to treat the princess. With him comes Vāruṇī, the princess's companion and the daughter of the teacher Kṛtaka. She travels with her younger brother, the

young student, but Karāla forcibly shuts his chamber and performs what he calls a *gāndharva* marriage with her. The first chapter's ninth and final section concludes with popular rebellion and the king fleeing on horseback.

Archers accompanied the trade caravan, bringing their dogs, and ordinary people travelled with the caravan as well. Varuṇa and Vāruṇī departed with them towards Aṅga, whose capital is named Campā and placed north of the Ganges.

The repeated references to "Aryanisation" show the influence of Western scholars upon Mayanandji. Both "Aryan" and "Dravidian," I argue, were terms brought into India by Westerners for their own vested interests. The text presents the expansion of Kosala and Videha and the entire history of the development of divinity. Mithila's familiar *dahi–cūṛā*, curd and flattened rice, is also mentioned.

Following agricultural production, people can exchange grain for other goods, and bullock carts can transport merchandise. The *bhūdevas*, or Brahmins, arrange a sacrifice lasting a month. In the course of language teaching, Brāhmaṇagāma becomes Bābhanagāma and Vanagrāma becomes Vanagāma by phonetic change. While returning from teaching the language, Vāruṇī is struck by an arrow and subsequently dies.

By the second spring the republican form of government in Mithila is securely established. Vaiśālī and Mithila begin discussions towards association in a republican framework. In the capital, Sitagrāma, Mithila's eastward expansion is discussed. A great forest lies between Sitagrāma and Jitagrāma in eastern Mithila, and the people of Brāhmaṇagrāma and Trigrāma jointly burn and clear it.

The development of the divine order in India is connected with ideas about water. As long as the world remains unmanifest, it is dark and is space; once manifest, it takes the form of water. Both space and water are elements of Indian thought. Mayanandji's depiction of image worship is an oversimplification, as is the method of linguistic dissemination represented in *Strīdhan*.

Literature preserves traditions through listening and oral transmission; this can be observed repeatedly in the *Mahābhārata*. One cannot, therefore, simply declare a number of its books interpolations on this ground. A study of the Vedic *Prātiśākhyas* would reveal that such a state of affairs was impossible alongside a written tradition; by the time of the *Mahābhārata*, however, rigidity had increased. The *Mahābhārata* gives the following description:

(१.६ विनयाधिकारिके प्रथमाधिकरणे षडोऽध्यायः इन्द्रियजये अरिषड्वर्गत्यागः): तद्विरुद्धवृत्तिरवश्येन्द्रियश्चातुरन्तोऽपि राजा सद्यो विनश्यति- यथा

("In the first book, chapter six, on discipline, conquest of the senses, and renunciation of the six inner enemies: even a king ruling the four quarters is quickly destroyed when he acts against these principles and cannot control his senses; as in the following example—")

दाण्डक्यो नाम भोजः कामाद् ब्राह्मण कन्यायमभिमन्यमानः सबन्धराष्ट्रोविननाश करालश्च वैदेहः,... ।

("The Bhoja named Daṇḍakya, through lustful aggression towards a Brahmin girl, perished together with his kin and kingdom; and so did Karāla of Videha ...")

In his *Jayamaṅgalā* commentary, the monk Prabhamati adds that Karāla, looking towards a crowd at the Yogeśvara pilgrimage site, saw a beautiful Brahmin woman and forcibly carried her off to his kingdom. The Brahmin went to Karāla's capital and, weeping and enraged, cried out, "Why does the earth not split open in a place where such a wicked king lives?" The earth split, and Karāla sank into it and died along with his family.

2. The Floods of Mithila

Abstract

The land of Mithila has long struggled against the devastation caused by floods. Around Kuśeśvarasthān, land remains submerged during the rainy season even without a river flood. Earlier this whole region was fertile; stagnant water began to accumulate there with the unchecked construction of embankments in India.

Keywords: Mithila · Floods · Critical Studies · Maithili

The land of Mithila has long struggled against the devastation caused by floods. Around Kuśeśvarasthān, land remains submerged during the rains even without a flood. This condition, however, dates from after 1978–79. Previously the entire region was fertile; stagnant water began accumulating with the uncontrolled construction of embankments in India. Yet one almost never hears news of flooding in this area. When reports do appear, they merely repeat the misleading claim that the accumulated water was released from Nepal. The people around Kuśeśvarasthān have learned the art of confronting this new calamity. I remember being advised to visit Mahīṣī's Ugratārā shrine from Kuśeśvarasthān during the floods because, I was told, travel by boat is easier then. In the dry season boats cannot pass through the pits and shallow hollows, and the less said about the roads the better. The cropping pattern has changed; through makeshift fish-rearing and other adaptations, this region has been forced to learn an entire way of surviving.

Whether the havoc wrought by Queen Kauśikī in 2008 will put an end to that disinformation remains to be seen!

Let us first ask who controls the two barrages on the Koshi and Gandak rivers in Nepal. Their control rests with the Water Resources Department of the Bihar government, and Bihar's engineers manage them. Decisions about releasing water are in the hands of that department. Nepal would have the authority to release water if dams or barrages were built on its other rivers. Yet even after more than fifty years, no agreement between the two countries has made such construction possible. Why?

The contemporary sequence of events. The Bhimnagar Barrage on the Koshi lies at Kusaha, Nepal. The barrage was built in 1958 with an estimated life of thirty years, which expired in 1988. Why could the two countries reach no agreement? Sand accumulating between the barrage structures is normally removed every year. Without this removal the bed level rises, and the embankments must then be raised year after year. Why was this work not begun on time that year? Then the rains arrived. On 18 August a breach two metres wide appeared in the Koshi embankment. I

witnessed the flood of 1987. Near the Jhanjharpur embankment the water struck with such force that it overflowed at one place, and before my eyes I saw a breach of one metre spread into a gap stretching kilometres. By 27–28 August 2008 the breach at Bhimnagar had reached two kilometres. The Koshi consequently abandoned its main channel and took a new course, devastating the Nepalese and Bihari parts of Mithila alike. NASA images dated 8 and 24 August 2008 showed a separation of 200 kilometres between the new and old courses of Kauśikī. The Bhimnagar Barrage had, in effect, become a barrage on a tributary channel of the Koshi.

A national disaster. When a disaster strikes a state, that state requests assistance from the central government. A team of central ministers visits the affected state and submits its report; another ministerial team considers that report and decides whether the calamity is a national disaster. While Bihar's politicians were busy blaming one another, forgetting their failures of fifty years, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh visited and declared it a national disaster. The reason was that it was a Level-3 disaster, beyond the capacity of the state alone—whether in financial resources or the ability to organise relief. Assistance was then being provided from the National Calamity Contingency Fund, and the waiver of farmers' loans was also possible.

What is to be done? The calamity at Kuśeśvarasthān comes every year, and everyone seems simply to have forgotten it. What, then, should be done now? Why could work like the Damodar Valley and Mayurakshi projects not be undertaken on the Koshi, Kamla, Bhutahi Balan, Gandak, Burhi Gandak, and Bagmati rivers? Why has Visvesvaraya's Vrindavan Dam succeeded? For how long shall we deceive the public by blaming the Nepal government? The only solution, I argue, is to use heavy machinery to demolish and remove the earthen embankments built on the Kamla–Balan and similar rivers and to replace unlined canals with properly constructed lined canals. There must be discussions with Nepal's government and a prompt settlement. Until then, short-term measures should be undertaken: remove sand deposited within the embankments before the rains; repair the embankments in advance instead of waiting for the monsoon; and keep political ambition out of all this work. Several new embankments would be needed to force the Koshi back into its former course, and these could never provide a lasting solution.

The Kamla River

Benefits and losses from canals. There is the problem of unlined canals, compounded by fundamental defects in design. One example will suffice to show how casually projects have been built. The principal western canal drawn from the Kamla runs from Jaynagar towards Umraon, from east to west. The land, however, slopes from north to south. What happens, or

must happen, during the rains? The canal turns into an embankment, trapping water to its north. Whether this canal-cum-embankment irrigates anyone's fields or not, crops on its northern side are certain to be submerged every year. A canal's route is changed so that some influential gentleman's land should not fall within it!

An embankment was built along the Kamla between Jaynagar and Jhanjharpur in 1960, and with it began the destruction of the entire region. I have already described what happened beyond Jhanjharpur in my account of Kuśeśvar. The stories of Madhepur, Ghanshyampur, and Singhia are no different. As sand accumulated between the two Kamla–Balan embankments, everything was devastated within twenty years of their construction. The Kamla joined the Balan near Pipraghat in 1954 when a large obstruction of driftwood from the Himalayan river blocked its route. Now its water level can rise by more than two metres in ten hours. From 1965 onward, sand accumulated so heavily between the embankments that people began demanding both their height be raised and, alternatively, that they be demolished.

The Koshi. Water reaches the Koshi from Mount Everest, Kanchenjunga, the Gaurishankar summit, and the Makalu range. In Nepal the Saptakoshi system comprises the Indravati, Sunkoshi (Bhote Koshi), Tama Koshi, Likhu Koshi, Dudh Koshi, Arun Koshi, and Tamor Koshi.

Of these, the Indravati, Sunkoshi, Tama Koshi, Likhu Koshi, and Dudh Koshi unite to form the Sunkoshi, which flows broadly west to east, although its tributaries flow broadly north to south. These five streams bring water from the Gaurishankar summit and the Makalu range.

The Arun Koshi draws its water from the Mount Everest (Sagarmatha) region and flows approximately north to south.

The Tamor Koshi flows broadly east to west, receiving water from the Kanchenjunga range.

The three branches—the Sunkoshi, Arun Koshi, and Tamor Koshi—meet at Triveni in Dhankuta district to become the Saptakoshi. Ten kilometres downstream lies Chatra, where the Mahakoshi, Saptakoshi, or Koshi descends onto the plains. After flowing roughly fifty kilometres southward through Nepal, the Koshi enters India near Hanumannagar–Bhimnagar. It turns a little towards the southwest, then towards the southeast and from west to east, and joins the Ganges near Kursela after a course of approximately 130 kilometres within India. The Bagmati and Kamla also join the Koshi around the meeting area of Saharsa, Darbhanga, and Purnia districts.

The first embankment on the Koshi was the Vīr Bāndh, built by Lakshman II in the twelfth century; its remains can still be found south of Bhimnagar.

Construction of the barrage near Bhimnagar was accompanied by the Eastern Koshi Embankment and the Eastern Koshi Canal.

In 1966 the Kunwar Sen Commission proposed a Dagmara Barrage twenty-three kilometres downstream of Bhimnagar to control the Koshi, but the plan became mired in controversy and politics. It offered two benefits: it could replace the Bhimnagar Barrage when the latter's service life ended, and it could develop inland water transport from Uttar Pradesh to Assam, greatly benefiting north Bihar. Yet the central irrigation minister, Dr K. L. Rao, did not allocate money for constructing it. The Western Koshi Canal was introduced instead, slowly and haphazardly; work on it was still continuing.

Nothing effective could be done for the Koshi. When proposals were made, they were rejected. The time in which the work should have been completed passed in dispute. A cheaper plan was approved in place of the Dagmara Barrage, but that plan too was still awaiting completion!

Visvesvaraya comes to mind. Dams were constructed on the Musi and Esi rivers, eighty-two miles from Hyderabad, and a subsidiary channel of the Musi was built six and a half miles from the city. Embankments were also raised along both banks inside the city. Visvesvaraya proposed that the Krishnaraja Sagar Dam be built to a height of 130 feet, and the Mysore state sent the plan to the British authorities. Viceroy Hardinge reduced the permitted height to eighty feet. Visvesvaraya compensated by widening the dam's lower section. A flood then intervened. He employed additional labour, appointed doctors for workers afflicted by malaria and other diseases, installed Washington lamps for working at night, and supervised the work personally to make up for the time lost. Such was his patriotism that he did not import cement. Instead the dam was built using *surkhi*, a mixture made from sand, calcium-bearing material, stone, and powdered fired bricks. A two-level canal system had already been constructed before the dam itself.

Delhi is still far away! In addition to the Prime Minister's and Chief Minister's disaster relief funds, Delhi residents can contribute to the funds of voluntary organisations.

But the long-term task is to exert pressure upon the central government in Delhi on the following points.

1. Why should schools and colleges not close during the flood season instead of having a summer vacation? What makes such a decision

difficult? Neither the CBSE nor the ICSE—nor even the Bihar Board—has managed to do this. If people in Delhi persuade the CBSE and ICSE to implement this change, the Bihar Board may follow out of sheer embarrassment.

2. Begin the Dagmara Barrage project in India, since the Bhimnagar Barrage has exceeded its designed service life. Funding should be obtained from the railway and road ministries as well, because a railway and road can—and should—be built across it.

3. While the barrage is being constructed, build lined canals in accordance with the natural slope of the land.

4. Demolish and remove the earthen embankments, make permanent embankments motorable, and plant sufficient trees on both sides.

5. As Bihar's road projects have begun to look like a dream coming true, remove every obstruction and begin work on all these measures on a war footing.

Only by forming a lobby in Delhi and exerting pressure on the central government and its ministries over these points can Bihar fashion a new image. Only then will the embankment undertaking begun in the twelfth century finally be completed, and the rivers be transformed into servants of humanity.

3. Society and Culture in the Lorik Epic

Abstract

The Lorik epic mentions neither a historically famous king nor the dates of Lorik's birth or marriage. Because its language has been preserved orally, its form remains fluid. Its dating is therefore based on conjecture.

Keywords: Lorik · Epic · Society · Culture · Critical Studies · Maithili

The Lorik epic mentions neither a historically famous king nor the dates of Lorik's birth or marriage. Because the medium of its language is oral, its form is continually changing, and attempts at dating are founded on conjecture. Lorik was born in the village of Gaurā, while the region of his exploits stretches from Punjab to Nepal and Bengal. His wife's ancestral village is Agaurī, said to stand beside the Son River.

Lorik's marriages. His first marriage was to Māǰarī of Agaurī; his second was to Canmā, who bore a son named Canraitā. He married a third time, to the sorceress Jamunī Baniyāin of Hardīgaṛh, by whom he had a son named Bosārakh.

Lorik's brother Sāṽarū, too, was a hero, but he was killed by the Kol king Devasiyā. Lorik was subsequently wounded in battle, and at the Bohā cattle station his son Bhorik defeated Devasiyā. In old age Lorik entered the fire in a final act of self-immolation.

The Lorik narrative. It includes the birth of Sābaur and Lorik's incarnation; the marriage of Sāṽarū; the birth of Māǰair; Lorik's marriage to Māǰair and his battles with King Maulāgat and Niramaliyā; the wedding of Sāṽarū and Satiyā; the conflict between Jhimlī and Lorik; the marriage of Canainiyā and Śivahar; and Lorik's battle with Beṇṭhā Camār. It recounts the love of Lorik and Canmā, their departure for Hardīgaṛh, and his conflicts with King Raṇpāl and Mahipat. Lorik and Canmā live in Hardīgaṛh; Lorik fights Gajbhimlā, attacks Neurpur, and fights Harebā–Barebā. Sāṽarū dies in the war against the Kol people. Lorik arrives at the Bohā cattle station, attacks Pīprīgaṛh, and fights Devasiyā; Lorik then departs this world and Bhorik assumes leadership. The first battle of Pīprī was fought alongside Sāṽarū, and the second alongside Lorik. Thereafter Lorik goes to Kāśī, where he dies.

The Religious, Social, and Political Aspects of the Lorik Manuār Epic

Lorik emerges without a known lineage-name or *gotra*. The Yadav community honours its revered Lorik through *chāṙ pūjā*, worshipping him as a folk divinity and venerating him as a people's hero.

A Maithili version of the *Lorikāyan* occurs in the collection of the archaeologist Alexander Cunningham. The *Quarterly Journal of the Mythic Society*, volume 5, pages 122–135, discusses the *Lorikāyan* of Bhagalpur. In Cunningham's travel account in the *Archaeological Survey Report*, volume 16 (1883), pages 27–28, Lorik and two neighbouring kings, Seuhar or Sarikkā, are described as inhabitants of the village of Gaurā.

John Hunter submitted a report on Lorik in the *Bhagalpur Gazetteer*, pages 48–50.

The Lorik epic is known as *Lorikāyan*, *Lorikī*, and *Lorik Maniār*. In Mithila it is celebrated under the title *Lorik Maniār*.

Lorik's grandson—his son's son—was named Indal. The Maithili *Lorik Maniār* discusses Lorik's marriage, the search for a bride for him, and his subsequent battle against King Sahdev in considerable detail.

The Mahuarī section describes the selection of a horse for visiting Gajbhīmal's wrestling ground and Lorik's killing of Gajbhīmal by repeatedly throwing him to the ground.

Lorik kills Harbā–Barbā.

The epic begins with *sumiran*, an invocation of remembrance, and *bandhan*, a song of homage.

Invocation (*sumiran*): "इनती करै छी दुरुगा मिनती तोहार।"
"I plead with you, Durgā; my supplication is to you."

Song of homage (*bandhan*): "आ-दुरुगा गइ पुरुब खण्ड हे गइ"
"Ah, Durgā went towards the eastern region, O she went."

Thereafter:

1. The Marriage Section; 2. The Mahuarī Section; 3. The War Section.

Maṇipadmā's division is as follows: 1. The Birth Section; 2. The Satī Māǰarī Section; 3. The Canain Section; 4. The Battle Section; 5. The Sāvar Section; 6. The Bājil Section; 7. The Reconciliation Section; and 8. The Bhairavī Section, obtained from Nepal.

—Buṛhkūvā Raut of Gaurā village used to make strips or splints from palm-tree trunks. He could carry five to seven hundred wrestlers on his back and walk fourteen *kos* before returning. Yet he had no household or property to speak of. He had two sons, Lorik Maniār and Sāod Sardār.

—Sevācan Raut, headman of Agaurī, wore a dhoti eighty yards long and a turban fifty-two yards long. He had a horse called Tetaliyā. His daughter Māǰarī played *suptī–maunī* with seven hundred companions. To arrange

her marriage, Sevācan went to Buṛhkūvā's house and challenged Lorik at the wrestling ground. Sevācan could rub his palms with fifty-six *man* of earth, but Lorik tossed him up like a small play-ball, caught him like a larger ball, and tucked him under his arm.

On the wedding day King Ugrā Pamār tried to seize Buṛhkūvā, who cut off the neck of the wrestler Bhakulā. The marriage took place. King Ugrā Pamār summoned Sanikā and Manikā, but Lorik beheaded both of them. When Lorik was travelling around Gaurā, King Sahdev of Hardī attacked him. Lorik defeated Sahdev, carried his daughter Canāi to Mahīcan's courtyard, and married her. King Mahuarī then imprisoned Mahīcan, but released him out of fear of Lorik. He nevertheless sent Gajbhīmal, commander of the Silhaṭ wrestling ground; Lorik severed his head, after which friendship was established with the king. Together they fought King Harbā–Barbā. Harbā–Barbā fled but sent the wrestler Dhuthrā. Lorik gouged out his right eye and cut out his tongue. Harbā–Barbā attacked again and fled; then came his nephew, Prince Anār. Lorik beheaded Anār and flung his head before Harbā–Barbā's queen Padmā. Harbā–Barbā attacked once more. On the battlefield of Dihulī, Lorik cut off the head of Harbā–Barbā, ruler of Hāvīgaṛh, and hurled it into the inner apartments of the royal palace. Lorik fought thirty-six battles. He was also attentive to the development of agriculture. One account tells how the occupation of another people's land displaced numerous birds, animals, and insects, which then went to Indra.

—An expansion of the power of those now placed near the bottom of the social hierarchy, and of women, in both spiritual and worldly senses.

—Conflicts between castes at different levels of the social hierarchy. Lorik destroys wicked characters belonging to castes now described as "lower." His devotion to the Goddess is said to be the cause of his victories.

But Lorik's enemies also include Mochanī and Gajbhīmal, who occupy supposedly higher places on the social ladder, while his friends include Rajal, placed among the supposedly lower castes.

He frees the Brahmin woman Duhbī–Suhbī and the Kṣatriya Gāĝe from the grip of King Harbā.

Ughrā Pāvār, Harbā–Barbā, Sonikā, Manikā, Baṇṭhā, Kolhamkaṛā, and Karṇā are kings or characters assigned to supposedly lower positions in the caste hierarchy. There is worship of the Mother Goddess; Indra's wife arrives disguised as Durgā, and Lorik, thinking her his own wife, touches her and suffers distress. Lorik is reunited with Māĵarī, and the journey to Kāśī follows.

—The epic is performed at fairs, markets, homes of prominent people, and public places, so its listeners are not confined to the Yadav community. Creator and audience have a direct relationship. The performance is intended to be heard; the story may receive spontaneous embellishment. Yet the formal literary features one might expect—organisation into cantos, metrical composition, dramatic junctures and their subsidiary elements, and a scheme for presenting the subject—are absent or irregular. The narrative is not tightly organised. Abuse occurs in the performance, and drinking is described here and there. Theft and the position of thieves in rural life are depicted. Local gods and goddesses are mentioned, and the epic functions as a symbol of caste identity. The epic singer is an extempore poet: he has a basic framework but sings it in his own manner, not by memorising every word. Invocations at the beginning and occasional appeals to God for forgiveness help him sustain his capacity to perform. During a performance lasting more than an hour, the hookah or *chillum*, the consumption of liquor, and descriptions of the surrounding environment may enter the singing. The singer may be illiterate yet possess a store of knowledge greater than that of a literate person. In *Lorik Maniār*, the number of listeners and their absorption and concentration affect the storyteller's performance, since he narrates directly before them. In this sense external influences bear more strongly upon him than upon the storyteller of Salhes, whose epic is recited before his chosen deity rather than before an audience.

Although the essential plot of the epic remains broadly the same, the mode of performance is distinctive because of the particular society, activities, and social conventions involved.

War, gambling, love, and marriage are cultural elements of the great epics. Gambling is a mental battle, and people themselves can become stakes, as in the *Mahābhārata* and the *Lorikāyan*.

The Goddess Durgā helps the hero in battle. Canain leaves Śivdhar and elopes with Lorik. Lorik gambles with Mahpatiyā of the Dusadh caste and loses Canain as a stake. She protests. Jewellery and ornaments are then staked; with sexually provocative gestures Canain distracts Mahpatiyā, allowing Lorik to win. Lorik cuts off Mahpatiyā's head. Even after her husband has behaved improperly, the wife offers him counsel.

Lorik's Incarnation and the Supernatural

In anger as in love, abusive speech belongs to the unrestricted cultural character of the poetry. Nature has not been hidden away; the hero himself uses abuse.

The worship of Śiva and Śakti, the borrowing of names and other elements from the great epics, reveal the openness and tolerance of the singer of

Lorik Maniār. His powers of performance and range of knowledge prevent me from calling him unlettered in the deeper sense.

Religious beliefs, the hero's character, and social custom are presented as a living cultural order. Most of the attributes of epic poetry—*rasa*, metre, poetic qualities, ornamentation, attention to cantos, prevailing religious values, cultural comprehensiveness, and the singer's creative power—can be found here.

To change the testimony gathered through fieldwork on folk-epic singing and dancing—for example, by removing abuse—according to one's own cultural moral standards is unforgivable. The researcher must place himself within that society while keeping the purpose of the study in view. Neither wording nor sentence construction should be altered. The epic concerns the protection of women and the village, the destruction of wrongdoers, and support for herders and cultivators.

Lorik's companions include Baṇṭhā Camār, Vārū the watchman (Paswan), Rajal the washerman, and his brother Sāvar.

The Salhes epic belongs to the Tarai region. There are many more descriptions of forests and wild animals, with wildlife assisting Salhes; hunting and sacrifice are also depicted. Clay horses are placed at places of Salhes worship, but not in the *Lorikāyan* tradition.

Lorik Maniār contains more supernatural and mysterious episodes but almost no wild animals in forest settings. Lorik is an incarnate hero, yet he is not worshipped through an established formal ritual.

The crow Bājil sets fire to Kolhamkaṛā's stronghold with a half-burnt cow-dung cake.

—Udhra–Pāvār's elephant, Kajjal Giri.

—Lorik's horse, Kaṭrā.

—The commander Barbā's horse, Barchebā.

—Bājil the crow.

Yet in the *Lorik Maniār* epic these are not wild animals: they are domesticated and cared for.

Lorik's actual Hardīgaṛh and his celebrated field of action, I argue, are at Hardīsthān in Saharsa district, because the name Durgāsthān is associated with Hardī east of Supaul. With this Hardī are associated Mahīcandra Sahu, King Mahbair, Neurpur (Nauhatta), Gājerīpur (Gauripur), Kherdahā (Khairā stream), Rahuā–Candrāyan–Mainā village, Bairāghāṭ, the Tilābe stream, Bairā grove, and Mahbairiyā village. The similarity between the anklets recovered from the epic site at Bairāghāṭ and those found in

excavations west of Hardī High School is offered as evidence of this connection.

A noticeboard of the Railways at Supaul station states: "Five kilometres east of here, at Hardī Durgāsthān, may be seen the historic sites associated with Goddess Durgā and the heroic Lorik."

Near Nauhatta there is a sage-associated site and a Pali-language inscription from the Pala period. Haridrāgaṛh extended over fourteen *kos*. The thirteenth-century *Varṇaratnākara* mentions Lorik; in its second *kallola* it also refers to the Lorik dance. Formerly this was a dance performance; today it is an epic recitation.

Neurī is a village thirteen kilometres east of Biraul subdivision in Darbhanga, where there is an old fort said to be connected with King Lorik.

4. The Exploration of Mithila

Abstract

This article presents a concise account drawn from more than a decade of my travels through Mithila. The contribution of local residents and guides at these places has been beyond description. Sometimes even the drivers of hired vehicles proved to be excellent guides.—Gajendra Thakur

1. Gauri–Shankar Sthan. Located between the villages of Jamthari and Hainthi Bali in Madhubani district, the site is particularly notable for a composite image of Gauri and Shankar and a Pala-dynasty inscription written on it in Mithilakshar.

Keywords: Mithila · exploration · criticism · Maithili

This article presents a concise account drawn from more than a decade of my travels through Mithila. The contribution of local residents and guides at these places has been beyond description. Sometimes even the drivers of hired vehicles proved to be excellent guides.—Gajendra Thakur

1. Gauri–Shankar Sthan. Situated between Jamthari and Hainthi Bali villages in Madhubani district, this place is particularly noteworthy for its composite image of Gauri and Shankar and the Pala-period inscription on it in the Mithilakshar script. Among ancient sites, it is exceptional in having been fully developed through the cooperation of enthusiastic local villagers. The bustle and festivities here during Shivaratri are worth seeing. The site lies two to three kilometres north of Bideshwar Sthan.

2. Bhith–Bhagwanpur Inscription. An inscription connected with Malladeva, son of King Nanyadeva, is found here. The site lies within Madhepur police-station jurisdiction in Madhubani district.

3. Hulas Patti. Near Jageshwar Sthan, within Phulparas police-station jurisdiction in Madhubani district, lies the village of Hulas Patti, where there is a black-stone image of Lord Vishnu.

4. Piprahi. All four arms of the Vishnu image in Piprahi village, within Laukaha police-station jurisdiction, have been broken.

5. Madhuban. At Madhuban village in Nepal, ten kilometres north of Piprahi, there is an image of four-armed Vishnu.

6. The Local Vachaspati Museum at Andhratharhi. The magnificent image of a yakshini from Gaud village is housed here.

7. Kamaladitya Sthan. The Vishnu temple at Kamaladitya Sthan, near Andhratharhi village, was established by Shridhar Das, minister of the Karnata king Nanyadeva.

8. Rakhbari. A Vishnu image kept beneath a tree in Rakhbari village, Jhanjharpur subdivision, was fashioned in the Gandhara style.

9. Pajebagarh, Banahi Tola. A Buddha image was once found here, but its present whereabouts are unknown. This site too is near Rakhbari village.

10. Musaharniya Dih. Three kilometres west of Andhratharhi, near Pastan village, is a high mound. It contains a single-chamber structure assigned to the Buddhist period, Buddhist images, coins, fragments of pottery and remains of Pajeba.

11. Bhagirathpur. An inscription in Bhagirathpur village near Pandaul provides information about the administration of Ramabhadradeva and Lakshminath, the last two rulers of the Oinwar dynasty.

12. Akaur. At Akaur village, twenty kilometres to the west and north of Madhubani, is a high mound with images dating to the Buddhist period.

13. Balirajpur Fort. Balirajpur village is five kilometres east of Babubarhi block in Madhubani district. To its south are the remains of an ancient fort, four kilometres long and one kilometre wide, enclosed by walls ten feet thick.

14. Asurgarh Fort. Mithila's second fort, near Mahadev Math on the bank of the Tilyuga watercourse at the northeastern boundary of Madhubani district, extends over fifty acres.

15. Jaynagar Fort. Mithila's third fort stands on the India–Nepal border, near ancient Jaipur and present-day Jaynagar. A copperplate inscription obtained from Panchobh village near Darbhanga mentions Jaipur.

16. Nandangarh. This fort lies twelve miles northwest of Bettiah. There are fifteen high mounds arranged in three rows.

17. Lauriya–Nandangarh. Located north of Nandangarh, this site contains an Ashokan pillar and a Buddhist stupa.

18. Dekuligarh. Three kilometres east of Sheohar district, beside the highway, are the remains of two forts, surrounded by moats.

19. Katragarh. At Katra village in Muzaffarpur stands a vast fort, with moats dug on all four sides, as at Dekuligarh.

20. Naulagarh. This fort, covering 350 acres, lies twenty-five kilometres north of Begusarai.

21. Mangalgarh. In Begusarai district, within Bariyarpur police-station jurisdiction, a high mound rises amid Kanwar Lake. This fort is located there.

22. Alauligarh. Near Alauli village, fifteen kilometres north of Khagaria, is a fort spread over one hundred acres.

23. Kichakgarh. In Purnia district, ten kilometres north of Dengraghat, this fort is situated east of the Mahananda River.

24. Benugarh. This fort stands on the bank of the Kawal watercourse within Tedhagachh police-station jurisdiction.

25. Varijangarh. Six kilometres south of Bahadurganj, this fort lies beside the Lonsawari watercourse.

26. Gautam Tirtha. Near Brahmpur village, six kilometres west of Kamtaul station, is a sacred tank known as Gautam Kund.

27. Halavarta. Sitamarhi town, thirty-five kilometres southwest of Janakpur, has the Halveshwar Shiva temple and Janaki temple. One and a half kilometres away, in the Pundarik area, is Sitakund. According to the tradition associated with Halavarta, Janaka found Sita while ploughing the field. Fairs are held here on Ram Navami (the ninth day of the bright fortnight of Chaitra) and Janaki Navami (the ninth day of the bright fortnight of Vaishakh).

28. Phulhar. At Phulhar village, within Harlakhi police-station jurisdiction in Madhubani district, lay Janaka's flower garden, where Sita used to gather flowers.

29. Janakpur. The Mithila-mahatmya section of the Brihad-Vishnu Purana describes the Janakpur region. In the seventeenth century, the saint Sur Kishore found two magnificent images of Rama and Janaki in the Sarayu River at Ayodhya and installed them in the Janaki temple at Janakpur. The present temple was built in 1911 through the patronage of the queen of Tikamgarh. The Yamuni, Gerukha and Dudhavati watercourses surround the town. Fairs are held on Ram Navami (Chaitra, bright-fortnight ninth), Janaki Navami (Vaishakh, bright-fortnight ninth) and Vivah Panchami (Agahan, bright-fortnight fifth).

30. Dhanusha. At Dhanusha Sthan, fifteen kilometres north of Janakpur, a bow-shaped fragment lies beneath a peepal tree. According to local tradition it is the bow broken by Rama. To its east flows the Banganga, said to have been brought forth by an arrow shot by Lakshmana.

31. Sugga. Near Jaleshwar Shivdham, close to Janakpur, Sugga village contains the hermitage of Shukadeva. Shukadeva came to Mithila to receive instruction from Janaka and was accommodated here.

32. Singheshwar. The Singheshwar Shiva pilgrimage site lies near Gauripur village, five kilometres from Madhepura.

33. Kapileshwar. The shrine of Mahadeva, established by the sage Kapila, is six kilometres west of Madhubani.

34. Kusheshwar. Northeast of Samastipur, sixty kilometres southeast of Laheriasarai and twenty-five kilometres west of Saharsa, this is a celebrated Shiva pilgrimage site. It also contains a bird sanctuary where, from November to March, many birds may readily be seen: white and black gaibar, lalsar, dighauchh, mail, nakta, gairi, gagan, silli, adhani, harial, chaha, karan and ratba. The local bird names are retained as recorded.

35. Simardah. This Shiva temple is near Thalwara station, beside Shivsinghpur village, founded by Shiv Singh.

36. Somnath. Somdev Mahadev is worshipped near the Sabhagachhi in Saurath village, Madhubani district.

37. Madneshwar. The Madneshwar Shiva shrine stands four kilometres east of Andhratharhi in Madhubani district.

38. Kundagram. Some thirty-two kilometres northeast of Hajipur, near Basadh–Vaishali and Vasokund, and two kilometres northeast of a fortified mound, lies Kundagram, where the twenty-fourth Jain tirthankara Mahavira is said to have been born. The site contains relics or ashes attributed to the Buddha, the Abhishek Pushkarini (the tank in which kings bathed before coronation), an Ashokan pillar and an assembly building (Raja Vishal's fort).

39. Chandeshwar. Near Hardi village at Jhanjharpur is the Chandeshwar Shiva shrine, established by Chandeshwar Thakur.

40. Bideshwar. This Shiva pilgrimage site near Lohna Road station in Madhubani district was established by Maharaja Madhav Singh. There is also an inscription from that period in the Mithilakshar script.

41. Shilanath. Shilanath Mahadev is worshipped on the bank of the Kamla watercourse near Jaynagar.

42. Ugranath. A shivalinga of Ugna Mahadev stands at Bhawanipur village near Pandaul station, south of Madhubani. When Vidyapati felt thirsty, Mahadev in the form of Ugna drew Ganga water from his matted hair and gave it to the poet to drink. At Vidyapati's insistence, Ugna revealed his true form as Shiva here.

43. Uchchaith Chhinnamastika Bhagavati. At Uchchaith, sixteen kilometres northeast of Kamtaul station, Kalidasa worshipped the Goddess. The original image of the Goddess is headless.

44. Ugratara. At Mahishi, the birthplace of Mandana Mishra, Ugratara is Mandana's family goddess.

45. Bhadrakalika. The Bhadrakalika temple is at Koilakh village in Madhubani district.

46. Chamunda. Near Katragarh in Muzaffarpur district, on the bank of the Lakshmana or Lakhandei watercourse, Durga slew Chanda and Munda. The temple stands at that place.

47. Parsa Sun Temple. A magnificent image of Surya, four and a half feet high, has been found in Parsa village, five kilometres east of Sangram near Jhanjharpur.

48. Bisfi. Bisfi village is within Benipatti police-station jurisdiction in Madhubani district, six kilometres east of Kamtaul railway station and four kilometres west of Kapileshwar Sthan. This is Vidyapati's birthplace; a memorial to the poet stands here.

49. Mandar Mountain. At this site in Banka there is a seventh-century Gupta-period inscription in Mithilakshar. Mandar was used, according to tradition, to churn the ocean. Nearby, at Bounsi, are two images of Vasupujya Nath, the twelfth Jain tirthankara. The larger image is of red stone; the other is bronze, with two footprints before it. Vasupujya Nath was born in Champanagar and attained nirvana here.

50. Vikramashila. The ancient university was situated in the Bhagalpur region. At Antichak village in Bhagalpur district stands the Buddhist university founded by King Dharmapala. Accommodation was built for 108 teachers as well as students arriving from elsewhere.

51. The Twenty Siddha Pithas of Mithila

1. Girija Sthan (Phulhar, Madhubani); 2. Durga Sthan (Uchchaith, Madhubani); 3. Raheshwari (Dokhar, Madhubani); 4. Bhuvaneshwari Sthan (Bhagwatipur, Madhubani); 5. Bhadrakalika (Koilakh, Madhubani); 6. Chamunda Sthan (Pachahi, Madhubani); 7. Sonamai (Janakpur, Nepal); 8. Yoganidra (Janakpur, Nepal); 9. Kalika Sthan (Janakpur Sthan); 10. Rajeshwari Devi (Janakpur, Nepal); 11. Chhinnamasta Devi (Ujan, Madhubani); 12. Banadurga (Khararakh, Madhubani); 13. Siddheshwari Devi (Sarisav, Madhubani); 14. Devi Sthan (Andhratharhi, Madhubani); 15. Kankali Devi (on the India–Nepal border and at Rambagh Place, Darbhanga); 16. Ugratara (Mahishi, Saharsa); 17. Katyayani Devi (Badlaghat, Saharsa); 18. Puran Devi (Purnia); 19. Kali Sthan (Darbhanga); 20. Jaimangala Sthan (Munger).

52. The Fifteen Stations of the Janakpur Pilgrimage Circuit and Their Principal Deities: 1. Hanumannagar—Hanuman; 2. Kalyaneshwar—Shivalinga; 3. Girija Sthan—Shakti; 4. Matihani—Vishnu temple; 5. Jaleshwar—Shivalinga; 6. Manai—the sage Mandav; 7. Dhruv Kund—Dhruva temple; 8. Kanchan Van—no temple, only beautiful scenery; 9.

Parvat—five hills; 10. Dhanusha—a piece of Shiva's bow; 11. Satokhari—the seven tanks of the Seven Sages; 12. Harushaha—Vimalaganga; 13. Karuna—no temple, only beautiful scenery; 14. Bisaul—Vishvamitra temple; 15. Janakpur. "Mithilādayaś ca madhyante ripavo iti Mithilā nagarī": Mithila is the city where enemies are crushed—an explanation attributed here to Panini.

53. Chainpur, Saharsa. This village has Mithila's only Nilkanth temple, as well as a magnificent Kali temple dating from an early period. Mahashivaratri and Kali Puja are celebrated with great enthusiasm at Chainpur.

54. Dharhara, Banmankhi, Purnia. There is a shrine of the Narasimha incarnation. A large, cave-like hollow gives forth a resonant "goṅ-goṅ" sound for a long time when something is thrown into it. The shrine has now been developed considerably, with an image and temple of Lord Narasimha.

55. Neuri. Thirteen kilometres west of Biraul block in Darbhanga is a fort believed to have belonged to Lorik.

56. Darbhanga Catholic Church. Established in 1891, this church was damaged by the earthquake of 1897. It is also known as Holy Rosary Church.

57. St Francis of Assisi Church is in Muzaffarpur.

58. Bhikha Salami Mazar. This shrine stands on the bank of Ganga Sagar pond in Darbhanga.

59. Darbhanga Tower Mosque is a magnificent mosque and religious place for adherents of Islam.

60. Makhdum Baba's Mazar. Situated between Lalit Narayan Mithila University and Kameshwar Singh Sanskrit University in Darbhanga, this shrine is sacred to both Hindu and Muslim devotees.

61. Champanagar. West of Bhagalpur, and now adjoining the town, Champanagar is a sacred place for Jains. Mahavira spent three rainy-season retreats here. There are two Jain temples dedicated to Vasupujya Nath, the twelfth Jain tirthankara.

62. Basaiti Inscription. This Mithilakshar inscription near Srinagar in Purnia district describes the reign of Queen Indravati, the first woman ruler of Mithila. Madneshwar Mishra based his novel *Ek Chhalih Maharani* (*There Was a Queen*) on it.

Baisi–Basaiti, Araria: a Mithilakshar stone inscription of Queen Indravati (1784–1802), who initiated food-for-work and other welfare activities. The

inscription is engraved on black stone fixed above a temple and reads as follows:

Devanagari transcription of the Mithilakshar inscription at the Shiva temple in Basaiti (Araria), Bihar.

वंशे सभा समाने सुरगन बिदिते भू सूरस्यावतिर्ना।
राजाभूतकृष्णदेवोनृपति समरसिंहा मिधस्यात्मजातः॥
यस्मिन् राज्याभिषेकं फलयितु मिवतद्भक्तितुष्टोमहेशः।
कैलाशाद् भूगतेद्योप्यधिन सततरा वैद्यनाथेन नाम्नाः॥
तस्य तनुजः सुकृतिनृपवरौ विश्वनाथ राजा भूत।
विरनारायण राजस्तस्याप्यासीद सुतस्य॥
नरनारायण राजो नरपति कुल मौलि भूषणम् पुनः।
अर्थिनकल्पद्रूमदूव सुरगन वंसावतंसोत्भूत॥२॥
तस्मादि वैरिकुल सूदन रामचन्द्र नारायणो नरपतिस्तनयो वभूक।
संमोदिता दश दिशो निज कीर्ति चन्द्र ज्योतिस्नेहाभिरार्थ निवहः
सुरिवतश्चयेण॥३।।
यद्दानवारि परिवर्द्धित वारि राशि सक्तान्त कीर्ति विमलेन्दु मरिचिकाभिः।
प्रोद्योतिता दशदिशः सतनुज इन्द्रनारायणोस्य कुलभूषण राजराजः॥४॥
तेनच सत्कुल जाता तनया मनबोध शझणिः कृतिनः।
परिणीता बन्धु यत्नैस्त्रिलोचननाद्रि पुत्रीव॥५॥
यस्या प्रतापतरणावुदितेऽपिचिते
चिन्तारजविन्द वनमालभते विकासम
सौहृदय हृदय मकरन्द च उद्यन
तत्रैव यद् गुणगणा मधुपन्ति योगात्॥६॥
यज्ञेवर्देव गणो द्विजाति निवहः सस्तायनत्यादरैः।
ददानैपूर्णः मनोरथोऽर्थपरन सन्तितिनिः सज्जना॥७॥
गर्ज्जद वैरि मदान्धवारण चपश्चञ्चःपेतापांकुरौ।
वंस्याः सर्वदृशेकृतागुण चमेर्मस्याश्च भूमीतनं॥८॥
श्री श्री इन्दुमति सतीमतिमती देवी महाराज्ञिका
जाता मैथिल माण्डराऽमिछ्कुलात् मोधोसरी जानयाः।
दानै कल्पलता मधः कृतवती श्री विष्णु सेवा परा
पातिव्रत्य परायणाच सततं गंगेर सम्पारणी॥९॥
शाकेन्दु नवचन्द्र शैलधरणी संलक्षित फाल्गुने
मासि श्रेष्ठतरे सिताहनि शितेपक्षे द्वितीयायां तिथौ।
भूदेवैर्वर वैदिकेर्म्मठमयं निर्भारय सच्चिनिमिः
तत्रे सेन्दुमति सुरस्य विधित्र प्राण प्रतिष्ठाव्यधात्॥१०॥
सोदरपुर सम्भव राजानुकम्पापजिवनिकृतिनः।
श्री शुभनायस्य कृतिमिदं विज्ञेक्षं सन्नन्तताम्॥११॥
(Images of the places described above are available at the following link: http: //www.videha.co.in/favorite.htm.)

5. The Dushan Panji (Register of Transgressions)

Abstract

A single scanned PDF of the Dushan Panji. My book on the genealogical registers also provided for the separate purchase of a DVD containing JPG images of 11,000 palm leaves. I even distributed that DVD at Sagar Rati Deep Jaray in Kabilpur. Yet the Dushan Panji contained in it provoked so many disputes and village adjudications. So many people abused me face to face and over the telephone. Even now many seethe inwardly at the mention of it in the panji and begin to pant with rage in conversation, as if they would drink blood.

Keywords: Dushan · Panji · criticism · Maithili

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This Dushan Panji contained written records of marriages between Brahmins and people of other castes, particularly Dalits, and between Brahmins and Muslims, as well as remarriages after a husband's death. It was not possible for me to alter those records. In my book on the panjis, they were transliterated word for word from Mithilakshar into Devanagari. I am providing links to the original registers written on palm leaves and on basaha leaves, as well as other panji links. Nobody can say that there is even the smallest error in them. One may find here the account of Gangesha's birth five years after his father's death and, later, his marriage to a woman of the Chamar community. This is the very Gangesha regarded as the founder of Navya Nyaya. His marriage to Ananda, a Chamar woman, is also recorded here; it furnished the basis for my love story *Shabdashastram*.

Dushan Panji—original writing in Mithilakshar, single PDF of palm-leaf manuscripts—https: //docs. google. com/a/videha. com/viewer? a=v&pid=sites&srcid=dmlkZWhhLmNvbXx2aWRlaGEtcG90aGl8Z3g6ZjFiNTA5NGI2YTVlNGEx

Modanand Jha branch register—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/modanand_jha_shakha_panji. pdf

Mandar–Marare Kashyap, ancient register—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/mandar_marare_kashyap_prachin_complete. pdf

Ancient register (laminated)—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/laminatedpanji. pdf

Uterh Panji—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/panji_7_uterh_panji. pdf

Panichobhe, Birpur—https: //sites. google. com/a/videha. com/videha-pothi/Home/Panichobhe_Birpur. pdf? attredirects=0

Darbhanga Raj orders, Uterh and related records—https: //sites. google. com/a/videha. com/videha-pothi/Home/DARBHANGA_RAJ_ORDER_PANJI_PACHHBARI_ORDER_UTEDH. pdf? attredirects=0

Chhoti Jha book directory—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/panji_directory_chotijha_shakha_pustak. pdf

Patra Panji—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/patra_panji. pdf

Mulgram Panji—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/panji_8_moolgram_panji. pdf

Mulgram Panji, arranged by pargana—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/panji_9_moolgram_parganawise_panji. pdf

Original Panji, volume 2—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/moolpanji_2. pdf

Original Panji, volume 3—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/mool_panji_3. pdf

Original Panji, volume 4—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/mool_panji_4. pdf

Original Panji, volume 5—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/mool_panji_5. pdf

Original Panji, volume 6—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/moolpanji_6. pdf

Original Panji, volume 7—http: //videha123. files. wordpress. com/2011/09/prachin_panji_last. pdf

Panji book—http: //www.box.net/shared/yx4b9r4kab

Two books had appeared: *Mithila ki Sanskritik Lokchitrakala* (*Mithila's Cultural Folk Painting*), 1962, by the painter Shri Lakshminath Jha; and *Genome Mapping: Mithilak Panji Prabandh, 450 AD to 2009 AD*, 2009, by Gajendra Thakur, Nagendra Kumar Jha and the genealogist Vidyanand Jha. The panji book is available at http: //www.box.net/shared/yx4b9r4kab,

and images of register leaves are available at https: //sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-pothi/. Now two people have taken portions of these books, passed them off under their own names and had them published; others have helped them do so. Sushila Jha published a translation of *Mithila ki Sanskritik Lokchitrakala* under her own name as *Aripan* (2008), even scanning and appropriating the photographs. The Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore, provided a publication grant, as the book itself states. Dr Yoganath Jha recently had *Genome Mapping: Mithilak Panji Prabandh, 450 AD to 2009 AD* published under his own name as *Panji-Prabandh (Vansh Parichay—First Part)* (2010). He was assisted by the Shrotriya community organisation *Maharaja Kameshwar Singh Sanskritik Vikas Manch*. How could that Shrotriya organisation object to the alleged appropriation of a book by Shri Lakshminath Jha, himself a Shrotriya? Look at the scanned pages above. Even the old thief Pankaj Parashar (http: //www.box.net/shared/75xgdy37dr), I say, would be ashamed to see these people.

Histories of Maithili journalism do not mention *Desil Bayna*, published from Kolkata by Ramlochan Thakur. An exception is Radhakrishna Chaudhary's *A Survey of Maithili Literature*, which does mention the Kolkata *Desil Bayna*. A periodical of that name appeared in 1982, and seventy of its pages have been scanned into a single PDF in the Videha archive. There readers will find many remarkable writings and works by different authors.

See: *Desil Bayna*—https: //docs. google. com/a/videha. com/viewer? a=v&pid=sites&srcid=dmlkZWhhLmNvbXx2aWRlaGEtcG9oaGl8Z3g6Njc3YmM2NmI4ODBkMzRmNQ

6. Mithila and Sanskrit

Abstract

Mithila and Sanskrit: The Relevance of Kameshwar Singh Sanskrit University. Mithila's relationship with Sanskrit is very old. Four of the six philosophical systems originated here.

Keywords: Mithila · Sanskrit · criticism · Maithili

Mithila and Sanskrit: The Relevance of Kameshwar Singh Sanskrit University

Mithila's relationship with Sanskrit is very old. Four of the six philosophical systems originated here. Two Vedic branches, Vajasaneyi and Chhandogya, still exist there, but only in name. In Mithila one meets many people who first become acquainted with the names Vajasaneyi and Chhandogya only at the time of marriage. In the middle of the night it is discovered that the bridegroom belongs to the Chhandogya branch, and a commotion arises among the women: "Now there will have to be two weddings; it will take a very long time." We have forgotten that Vajasaneyi and Chhandogya are branches of the Shukla Yajurveda and the Samaveda respectively. On a visit undertaken in connection with official work—

—I went to the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts and had an opportunity to see a DVD on the Vedas. Vedic branches remain alive even today in Odisha, Maharashtra, Kerala, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu. In our own region, although the branches still nominally exist, people are ignorant both of their names and of their meaning.

Kavikulaguru Kalidas Sanskrit University was established at Ramtek, Maharashtra, through the efforts of Prime Minister Narasimha Rao. Within a short period, this university began conducting Sanskrit conversation camps throughout Maharashtra, year after year. It has published children's books in twenty-three volumes, although its buildings are still under construction.

Kameshwar Singh Sanskrit University, Darbhanga, rescued many works of Sanskrit–Maithili poetry. But its contribution has now dwindled, it seems, to publishing one annual almanac; even the calculations used for that university's *panchang* have become controversial.

From this issue onward, however, I have begun documenting the creative work the university once accomplished.

More than twenty years have passed since the university published critical editions of plays combining Sanskrit, Prakrit and *desil bayna*, the vernacular tongue. Because of this mixture of languages, these plays are

counted as works of both Sanskrit and Maithili literature. The songs expressing emotional intensity were composed in the soft, melodious language of Mithila. The first text edited and published by the university was Jyotirishwar Thakur's *Dhurttasamagama*.

Dhurttasamagama was composed by Jyotirishwar Thakur in the thirteenth century. He included Maithili songs in it. It belongs to the genre of *prahasana*, the farcical play. Most plays and short dramas in Maithili were based on the lives of Shri Krishna or his descendants, and on narratives of abduction or *swayamvara*. In *Dhurttasamagama*, however, a holy man and his disciple are the principal characters. Every character is more of a rogue than the last. Hence its title, "A Gathering of Rogues", is thoroughly appropriate. A *prahasana* is also called a musical farce, and the inclusion of Maithili songs is entirely fitting. Its principal characters are the stage manager, the actress, Snatak, Vishvanagar, Mritangar, Suratpriya, Anangsena, Asajjati Mishra, Bandhuvanchak, Mulnashak and Nagarik. The stage manager begins by praising the Karnata sovereign Narasimhadeva; he then sings the praises of Jyotirishwar. There is an element of absurdity in the play that feels distinctly modern. Its flexibility and elasticity make it a form of folk theatre.

In the absence of a woman, Vishvanagar lives as a celibate. He goes begging with his disciple Snatak to the house of Mritangar Thakur, only to be turned away on the pretext of ritual impurity following a death or birth. Vishvanagar and Snatak then go to Suratpriya's house for alms. A quarrel breaks out between master and pupil over a courtesan named Anangsena. They next go with Anangsena to Asajjati Mishra, only to discover that Mishra himself is a libertine ...

Mishra turns out to be a libertine ... He believes that gambling and sexual intercourse are the two essential things in the world. Asajjati Mishra asks who is the complainant and who the defendant. Snatak replies, "I am the complainant, because I have brought the charge; the ascetic is the defendant, because he must pay the fee." Vishvanagar offers Snatak's bundle of cannabis as his fee. The clown whispers praises of Anangsena's sexual charms in Asajjati Mishra's ear. Keeping Anangsena between the two claimants, Mishra gives judgment in his own favour. Meanwhile, the clown tells Anangsena in her ear, "This ascetic is poor, Snatak is a wanderer, and Mishra is a fool; stay with me instead." Anangsena looks around at all four men and exclaims, "This really has become a gathering of rogues!"

Vishvanagar and Snatak once again head towards Suratpriya's house.

Meanwhile Mulnashak the barber demands a year's earnings from Anangsena. She sends him to Asajjati Mishra. Taking Mishra to be

Anangsena's bridegroom, Mulnashak accepts cannabis as his fee, ties Mishra up and massages him so vigorously that he loses consciousness. Thinking Mishra dead, the barber flees.

The clown arrives, unties Mishra and asks, "I have saved your life. Tell me if there is anything else you would like me to do." Asajjati answers, "I have consumed the wealth of the whole land by deceit, obtained this beloved through roguery, and acquired an obedient disciple like you. Nothing more could please me now. Nevertheless, I wish peace and happiness everywhere."

The Position of Sanskrit in Mithila

The following institutions in the Mithila region have applied for affiliation to Kavikulaguru Kalidas Sanskrit University at Ramtek. Just as disorganisation within the Bihar School Examination Board caused the number of schools affiliated to the Central Board of Secondary Education to increase, so the disorder at Darbhanga's Sanskrit university has compelled good institutions to look outside the region for affiliation.

1. J. N. B. Sanskrit Vidyalaya, Bihar; Post Lagma (R. B. Pur), via Lohna Road, District Darbhanga.

2. Laxmiharikant Sanskrit Primary and Secondary School, Post Jhanjharpur Bazar, District Madhubani.

3. Ajitkumar Mehta Sanskrit Shikshan Sansthan, Post Ladora, District Samastipur.

4. Dr Mandanmishra Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya, Post Sanjat, District Begusarai.

5. Saraswati Adarsha Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya, Begusarai.

6. Dr R. M. Adarsha Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya, Post Office Malighat, Muzaffarpur.

In addition, the Rashtriya Sanskrit Sansthan, New Delhi, has kept the following institutions functioning by providing grants.

1. J. N. B. Adarsh Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya, Post Office Lagma, via Lohna Road, District Darbhanga.

2. Laxmi Devi Saraf Adarsh Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya, Kali Rekha, District Deoghar.

3. Rajkumari Ganesh Sharma Sanskrit Vidyapeetha, Kolahnta Patori, District Darbhanga.

4. Ramji Mehta Adarsh Sanskrit Mahavidyalaya, Malighat, Muzaffarpur.

Among these, the institution at Lagma sought affiliation to Kavikulaguru Kalidas Sanskrit University because the Darbhanga university has no such programme at all.

Dr Ramprakash Sharma's history of Mithila, written in Hindi, was also published thirty years ago. Today the university has neither its own website nor any distance-education programme.

The second play published by Kameshwar Singh Sanskrit University is the great poet Vidyapati's *Gorakshavijaya*. Earlier, plays based on Krishna predominated. In this sense *Gorakshavijaya* can be called a revolutionary drama.

The plot of this drama is organised around the story of the yogi Gorakhnath, founder of the Nath or Gorakh tradition. His guru Matsyendranath has abandoned yoga and, as king of Kadalipur, indulges in sensual pleasures with eighteen queens. The gatekeeper prevents Gorakh and Kananipad from entering. The minister also has a drum beaten to proclaim that no yogi is to be admitted anywhere, and the queens are told to keep the king enchanted. Gorakh and Kananipad disguise themselves as dancers and perform an entrancing dance before the king. Meanwhile the king's only son, Baudhanath, dies while playing. The king suspects the dancers and orders their execution; but they bring the child back to life. When the king asks who they are, Gorakh recounts everything about the king's earlier birth and tells him: “You are a yogi, not a pleasure-seeker.”

The characters also include Mahamati, the king's minister, and Mahadevi, Matsyendranath's senior queen. Matsyendranath is king of Kadalipur and a yogi in his previous birth. At the end he says, “May everyone have a disciple like Gorakh and may all women be like Mahadevi.” Kameshwar Singh Darbhanga Sanskrit University used to publish the quarterly Sanskrit journal *Vishvamanisha*. It was published from 1975 to 1994, but publication has been suspended for fourteen years. Besides the Hindi history of Mithila, seven volumes of traditional Maithili plays were published, comprising sixteen dramas composed between AD 1300 and 1900. Pandit Shashinath Jha translated into Sanskrit *Vatavaran*, a Maithili play by Pandit Govind Jha, and the university published it. The university also published *Smriti-Sahasri*, by Buddhi Dhari Singh “Ramakar”, described as the first Maithili epic devoted to the life of a twentieth-century scholar and spiritual practitioner. A book entitled *Rupaka Samuchchayah* contains four dramatic works. Its fourth Sanskrit drama, *Dhurttavidambana Prahasanam* by Mahamahopadhyaya Amareshwar, is accompanied by a Maithili translation. *Rajanitisarah* by Mahamahopadhyaya Bhavnath Upadhyaya has likewise been supplied with a Maithili translation.

At present, the university seems to have confined its activities to preparing an almanac once a year.

7. Migration from Mithila

Abstract

The arrival of outsiders in Mithila and the migration of people from Mithila to distant lands have both been continuing processes. Contemporary migration, however, has become particularly acute because the exodus of the past thirty years has emptied Mithila's villages. The construction of the Mahatma Gandhi Setu near Patna in 1981 and the lines of deluxe coaches between Patna and Darbhanga facilitated the departure of large crowds of Mithila's inhabitants. Failure by successive governments in the political, economic, educational, social and cultural spheres certainly provided one foundation for this migration. The thirty years following independence also drew a line of separation between Mithila in Bihar and the Maithili-speaking region of Nepal.

Keywords: migration from Mithila · criticism · Maithili

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The construction of the Mahatma Gandhi Setu near Patna in 1981 and the lines of deluxe coaches between Patna and Darbhanga facilitated the departure of large crowds of Mithila's inhabitants. Failure by successive governments in the political, economic, educational, social and cultural spheres certainly provided one foundation for this migration. The thirty years following independence also drew a line of separation between Mithila in Bihar and the Maithili-speaking region of Nepal. The Kamla embankment built in 1960 and the still-unfinished Koshi project shattered the economic foundations of rural Mithila.

There is another fundamental difference between migration in ancient times and migration today. From ancient times, Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas of Mithila travelled to display their learning, to study and teach, and to earn their livelihoods at the courts of other kings. People of castes other than Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas travelled to distant lands for trade, employment as bodyguards and similar work. In ancient times Morang, and later Bhadohi, became centres where the labour of Mithila's agricultural workers was bought. Morang itself falls within the Mithila region of Nepal, but going there came to be called migration because its rulers were now non-Maithil Gorkhas.

Different Forms of Migration. Migration is part of a historical process. It also depends on the country in which geographical circumstances have placed your own region. Thus, although Morang was close, it later became less popular with the inhabitants of Indian Mithila: its location in a

different country made migration there unsuitable for a variety of reasons. After independence Kolkata was the nearest metropolitan centre, and many people migrated there. But when narrow political and economic policies ruined Bengal's industries and diminished its importance as a centre of education, Mumbai and Delhi became the new destinations. Agricultural labourers now go not to Bhadohi and Morang but to Punjab, Haryana and western Uttar Pradesh, while traders arriving from outside have filled Mithila. Jagdish Prasad Mandal's literature fully reveals how the mistaken economic policies of the Darbhanga Raj enabled people from Ara and Chhapra to become owners of land and estates. In 1936–37 people from Bhojpur and Buxar also fled Burma and arrived in Purnia and Araria. Hari Babu of Dumraon had settled them in Burma; after Burma was separated from India, they came as refugees to this region. One finds many Burma Tolas in these areas. These migrants, too, acquired a foothold in regional agriculture and commerce. Migration into Mithila also followed the creation of Bangladesh in 1971: Hindus from there arrived in Kishanganj, followed later by Muslims who settled in Purnia and Kishanganj. This inward migration, running counter to the outward exodus, affected Mithila's speech and many other aspects of life. As caste- and religion-based marriages among Muslims, Rajputs and Bhumihars increasingly took place beyond Mithila's geographical boundaries, differences in speech and expression became visible as well.

Is Migration Good or Bad? Migration, both outward and inward, cannot be stopped by any means. But the severe movement of people within a single generation has produced an acute problem: the migration and erosion of indigenous Maithil speech and expression. It brought deliverance from the starvation caused by floods and famines, yet it also brought a cultural famine. Pressure on the villages declined. People formerly unable to obtain land for sharecropping can now secure it. Conversely, educational centres within Mithila have been almost completely eliminated, while outside traders have taken command of the local economic market. Vast road projects, information technology, television, newspapers and magazines have become so concentrated in the hands of capital that they are beyond the means of local traders. When outside capitalists have entered the region's seats in the Rajya Sabha and Legislative Council, what more remains to be said?

A Remedy for Migration. Mere lamentation about migration will achieve nothing. Just as the Israeli diaspora has proved a source of strength for Israel, the Maithil diaspora too can become a source of strength for Mithila, supporting its language, culture, literature and economy. Alongside the demand for a Mithila state, intermediate demands must also be pressed: Maithili should be the medium of primary education in the Maithili-speaking areas of Bihar; there should be a Maithili radio station;

licence fees for Maithili television channels should be reduced; and Maithili newspapers and magazines should receive government advertisements. A separate state will come when it comes. If even two or three of the preceding demands are met, that will be an achievement. Only when awareness grows among the people will they be able to think seriously about the economic, educational and political condition of a Mithila state and join the movement for it.

8. Mithila's Pañjī System: Lineage, Marriage, Dūṣaṇa, Social Memory and Modern Reinterpretation

Abstract

Lineage, marriage, dūṣaṇa, social memory and modern reinterpretation: an integrated investigation of lineage memories said to extend from CE 450 to 2009, the ancient pañjīs, the nagarām registers, the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī and genome mapping. Monolingual Maithili · without superscript references · source disagreements made explicit · extended bibliography · audit of coverage of all twenty sources (20/20).

Keywords: Mithila · pañjī · record system · lineage · marriage · dūṣaṇa · social memory.

Abstract

This chapter discusses "Mithila's Pañjī System: Lineage, Marriage, Dūṣaṇa, Social Memory and Modern Reinterpretation." It presents an integrated study of genealogical memory said to extend from CE 450 to 2009, ancient pañjīs, nagarām, the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī and genome mapping. It is written in monolingual Maithili, without superscript citations, with source disagreements identified, an extensive bibliography and a 20/20 source-coverage audit. Mithila's pañjī system is extraordinary among India's genealogical traditions. Available reports describe it variously as a "human database," a "social technology," "lineage memory," a "judicial instrument of marriage eligibility," "genome mapping" and a "counter-archive." Each term reveals a different facet.

An Integrated Research Essay

Mithila's Pañjī System

Lineage, Marriage, Dūṣaṇa, Social Memory and Modern Reinterpretation

An integrated study of lineage memories said to extend from CE 450 to 2009, the ancient pañjīs, nagarām, the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī and genome mapping.

Form of the essay: A logical integration of twenty research reports, analyses, question-and-answer collections and studies of the pañjī, removing repetition while preserving distinctive facts, examples, divergences of opinion, social history and critical objections.

Editorial Framework

Monolingual Maithili · no superscripts · explicit acknowledgement of conflicting sources · extended bibliography · audit of all twenty sources (20/20).

Central point: To call the pañjī system merely a genealogy is to grasp only half its meaning. It is simultaneously a means of verifying marriage eligibility, a village-based social map, a record of scholarly titles and occupational change, a testimony to women's indirect presence, a document of both the discipline and transgressions of the caste order,

and a system of memory extending from handwritten manuscripts to digital archives.

Introduction: The Many Forms of a Living Archive

Mithila's pañjī system is an exceptional form among India's genealogical traditions. Available reports describe it variously as a "human database," a "social technology," "lineage memory," a "judicial instrument of eligibility for marriage," "genome mapping," and even a "counter-archive." Each designation illuminates a different aspect. Individuals do not enter the pañjī merely along a father–son line: it may also record their gotra, pravara, mūla, village of origin, branch, maternal connections, marital relationships, honorifics, occupation, changes of residence, royal or academic distinction and, in many cases, a social "blemish." Thus a pañjī becomes at once a genealogy, a social geography, a record of marriage rules, a history of occupations and a text of cultural memory.

The integrated body of sources includes general accounts of the pañjī system; interpretations of the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī's ninety-seven tables; the opening sections of the ancient pañjī; pages 66–347 of Volume I and pages 348–690 of Volume II; various blocks of the nagarām pañjī; the Pañjikā–Nagarāmī; a volume entitled "Genome Mapping"; research reports; comparative theories of genealogy; and an extensive question-and-answer collection. Certain reports repeat the same facts in different language, under different theoretical frameworks or with differing claims. Repetitions have been removed in this integrated study, but incompatible claims have not been discarded: they are identified explicitly as differences between sources.

A Caution on Reading the Sources

Differences between sources and levels of evidence: Some reports claim an "unbroken" genealogical memory from CE 450 to 2009, whereas the density of surviving material at the level of specific manuscripts is much greater for medieval and especially late-medieval and modern periods. There are also chronological discrepancies between the dates assigned to Harisinghdev's rule and the account of institutionalisation in Śaka 1248/CE 1326. Statements concerning "genomes" or "chromosomes" are interpretative analogies made by the source authors, not scientifically established equivalences in modern genetics. The essay therefore presents such statements as claims, analogies or traditional interpretations, not as demonstrated scientific facts.

1. Mithila: Geography, Intellectual Traditions and the Social Ground of the Pañjī

The sources identify Mithila by historical names such as Videha, Tirabhukti, Tirhut and Mithilanchal. Its cultural extent is described as stretching from the Himalayas in the north to the Ganges in the south, and from the Gandak in the west to the Mahananda in the east. Modern political boundaries do not diminish this cultural geography. The pañjīs

repeatedly attest connections with Darbhanga, Madhubani, Sitamarhi, Muzaffarpur, Saharsa, Supaul, Purnia, Katihar, Araria, Champaran, and the Bhagalpur–Munger region of northern Bihar, as well as Nepal's Terai and the areas around Janakpur and Kathmandu.

Mithila's scholarly tradition has been associated with institutions teaching Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā, Vedānta, grammar, astrology and Dharmaśāstra. The pañjī reports do not separate this intellectual tradition from hereditary lineages. Titles such as Mahāmahopādhyāya, Naiyāyika, Vaiyākaraṇa, Jyotirvid, Paṇḍitarāja, Sāhityācārya, Vaidika and Ācārya are recorded beside personal names in genealogical entries. In later periods, the same lines begin to include lawyers, judges, professors, engineers, IAS and IPS officers, DIGs, MA and PhD holders, university vice-chancellors, income-tax officers and other modern appointments. This continuity makes the pañjī not simply a remnant of an old society but an archive of a changing one.

An important social conclusion of the reports is that the name of a village in the pañjī is not merely an address. The mūlagrāma, or ancestral village, becomes a social "coordinate." When a family leaves its original village for another settlement, city or country, both its origin and its new residence must be remembered; otherwise the calculation of marital relationships may fail. Thus Mandar, Sodarpur, Karmaha, Darihara, Khaual, Sarisab, Pali, Belaunch, Jajiwal, Pandua, Pabauli, Saurath, Mahishi, Loa–Sugaon, Rajgram, Simraongarh, Katihar, Kolkata and places in Nepal all come within a single network of records.

2. From Group Records to the Pañjī System: A History of Institutionalisation

An earlier form of the pañjī tradition is discussed under the name *samūha-lekhya*, or collective record. Drawing on a statement in Kumārila Bhaṭṭa's *Tantravārttika*, the reports say that distinguished or ritually observant families preserved written accounts of their grandfathers' and great-grandfathers' lines, virtues and defects, and eligibility for marriage. It would be inappropriate to regard this reference as direct evidence of the institutional inauguration of the pañjī system. It does, however, show that the idea of family-based lineage memory and written genealogical lists existed long before the medieval period.

Accounts of the transition in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries are associated with Harinath Upadhyay. Different versions of the story survive. In one, the scholar Harinath Upadhyay, lacking complete genealogical knowledge, married within a prohibited degree of close kinship. In a more elaborate version, his wife was accused of a relationship with the Dusadh community; her hand was burned during an ordeal by fire. The scholar

Lakhima's explanation then revealed that the wife was not adulterous: rather, the husband himself was involved in a Dharmaśāstric predicament because of marriage to a prohibited relative. The account of a second examination suggests that the central problem was understood less as a moral failing than as an absence of genealogical knowledge.

The sources disagree about the historicity, date and details of this episode, but the reports emphasise one point: the keeping of lineage memory moved beyond reliance on individual families and became a professional, written and institutional practice. Śaka 1248, corresponding to CE 1326, is given as its traditional date of institutionalisation. The order is associated with Maharaja Harisinghdev; some reports, however, place the end of his rule around CE 1324, producing a chronological conflict. It is therefore safer here to call 1326 the traditionally accepted date of the system's institutionalisation, rather than an indisputable modern historical fact establishing every detail of the narrative.

Gunakar Jha is named as the principal genealogist for Brahmin pañjīs, Shankardatta as the official responsible for Karna Kayastha records, and Vijayadatta as the person entrusted with Kshatriya pañjīs, particularly those of the Gandhawariya Rajputs. Some reports refer to a "Vishvachakra conference" or an extensive survey of lineages in the Jamsam/Pandaul region. Surveyors or regional collectors sought genealogical information from elderly members of families, compared it with other families' records and established each lineage's mūla, founding male ancestor (*bījī puruṣa*) and branch. The process illuminates the transition from oral recollection to cross-verified written records.

Some reports give particular prominence to the learned Lakhima, also called Thakurain Lakhima. They portray her as a formidable scholar of Dharmaśāstra, a daughter of Rati Mishra, and an intellectual associated with the Nyāya and Dharmaśāstra traditions. The account demonstrates the presence of women in the intellectual world, although the chief genealogical structure remained centred on male descent.

2a. An Expanded Tradition of Institutionalisation: Assemblies, Women Scholars and Social Rites

Several reports present the institutionalisation narrative in greater detail. According to them, an assembly of learned people called the "Vishvachakra Conference" convened in the Jamsam/Pandaul region to formulate a royal plan for collecting village-by-village information about lineages, gotras, pravaras, mūlas, places of migration and marriages. Some sources date this meeting to 1327, whereas institutionalisation is dated to Śaka 1248, or CE 1326. The one-year discrepancy could reflect different

stages of the order, survey and conference; nevertheless, independent verification of the original royal document remains necessary.

The expanded tradition accords special importance to the woman scholar Thakurain Lakhima. She is represented as an accomplished scholar of Dharmaśāstra who understood the genealogical complexities of Harinath Upadhyay's predicament. In some versions, the learned assembly failed to resolve the problem following the ordeal by fire; Lakhima then unravelled the lines of kinship and identified the prohibited relationship. The story can be read at three levels: possible historical event, folk memory, and symbol of institutionalisation. Without contemporary primary evidence, her role is best described as "an account preserved within the pañjī tradition."

Vājasaneyī and Chāndogya

One report distinguishes two principal groups of Maithil Brahmins by Vedic ritual tradition: the Vājasaneyīs, associated with the Mādhyandina branch of the Śukla Yajurveda, and the Chāndogyas, associated with the Kauthuma branch of the Sāmaveda. It also records certain differences in initiation and marriage rites. The four stages given for Vājasaneyī initiation are cūḍākaraṇa, upanayana, vedārambha and samāvartana; the Chāndogya list comprises nāmakaraṇa, cūḍākaraṇa, upanayana and samāvartana. The Vājasaneyī marriage procedure is described as one continuous ceremony, while the Chāndogya procedure has two parts, "pre-marriage" and "post-marriage," the latter being performed at night after the sighting of Arundhatī. These ritual distinctions belong to the social background of marriage rather than to the essential genealogical structure of the pañjī. Practice can vary by region, family and period.

The Wider Classification of Pañcagauḍa and Pañcadrāviḍa

The source report places Maithil Brahmins within the northern Indian "Pañcagauḍa" grouping—Utkala, Kānyakubja, Gauḍa, Maithila and Sārasvata—and gives the traditional "Pañcadrāviḍa" list south of the Vindhyas: Karṇāṭa, Gurjara, Tailaṅga, Drāviḍa and Mahārāṣṭrīya. This broader, post-Purāṇic social classification represents a level of identity distinct from the local gotra–mūla arrangements of the pañjī. It should be understood as a historical Brahmanical self-classification, not as an immutable category in modern ethnic or linguistic science.

3. Types of Pañjī: A System of Multiple Registers

Different reports divide the pañjīs into seven types. Spellings and descriptions of their functions vary slightly; the integrated classification is as follows:

Mūla pañjī — the foundational register of original lineages, ancestral villages, founding male ancestors and primary identities.

Śākhā pañjī — the branches arising from a mūla, new places of residence, social subgroups and, in some periods, special sections such as *upaṭīpa* or nagarām.

Gotra pañjī — classification of gotras, pravaras and ancient mūlas.

Patra pañjī — a living register of descendants, new generations and the formation of marital links.

Dūṣaṇa pañjī — a record of lineage "degradation," marriages contrary to rules, unknown maternal descent, inter-caste or inter-religious relationships, social disputes or marks of alleged blemish.

Uṭeḍh/uteḍh pañjī — the pre-marital checking of ancestors through an extensive map of the maternal and paternal lines.

Asvajanya-patra/siddhānta-patra — a certificate establishing the absence of prohibited blood relationships and a formal ruling on eligibility for marriage.

Some sources describe an especially careful preservation of women's names in the *asvajanya-patra pañjī*, citing instances from the Rasaḍh–Araria region. Other sources emphasise the scarcity of women's names in the principal registers. Both observations can be true: the main patrilineal series often identifies women by relational formulas such as "the daughter of so-and-so's son from such-and-such a village," while special registers, marital checks or exceptional entries may record a woman's name, occupation or achievements.

The Pañjī as a "Relational" Archive

The analogy with a modern database recurs throughout the sources. A person's name provides the primary identity in an entry; the father, mūla, village, maternal village, *dau/ddau* relationship, references to branches, page numbers and other volume codes function as interlinked references. Codes such as "B 41/8," "U. Pra. 270/5" and "270/2" work rather like paper hyperlinks. The analogy is useful, but the pañjī was not a modern database: its structure depended upon terse written formulas, expert memory and consultation between several manuscripts.

4. Gotra, Pravara, Mūla, Ancestral Village and Founding Male Ancestor

Four levels constitute the basic identities involved in reading the pañjī: gotra, pravara, mūla and ancestral village. The gotra is the broad patrilineal tradition associated with a sage. Pravara is the ritual identity of a group of Vedic seers. Mūla is a historical branch or lineage unit within a

gotra. The *mūlagrāma* is the geographical place associated with the *bījī puruṣa*, or earliest known male ancestor. When a family settled elsewhere, its new settlement was appended as a branch or place of residence.

The reports list twenty gotras: Śāṇḍilya, Vatsa, Sāvarṇa, Kāśyapa, Parāśara, Bhāradvāja, Kātyāyana, Garga, Kauśika, Ālambukākṣa, Kṛṣṇātreya, Gautama, Maudgalya, Vasiṣṭha, Kauṇḍinya, Upamanyu, Kapila, Viṣṇuvṛddhi, Tāṇḍi and Jātūkarṇa. The number of gotras actually represented may be smaller in a particular volume: one numerical account of an ancient pañjī volume, for instance, identifies seventeen active gotras. This need not be a contradiction; it can reflect the difference between actual representation in one volume and the full conventional list.

The lists of pravaras distinguish groups of three and five seers. The sources particularly cite the Vatsa and Sāvarṇa gotras: although the gotras are different, their pravara seers are regarded as identical, so traditional marriage checks prohibit a union between the two. This example shows that the pañjī system does not stop at asking whether the gotras are different; it also considers identity of pravara.

The total number of mūlas is given as 167. The "principal" mūlas were initially numbered at thirty-four, but later counted as thirty-five after the Khanam branch of the Phanandaha mūla was included; several reports repeat this account. A traditional division places these thirty-five among the *Āyanta Śreṣṭha*, *Prajāyanta* or second-tier, and middle-tier mūlas. Their spellings differ between reports: Khaḍaure/Khaḍaurai, Khaual/Khauar, Budhbāḍ/Budhwāl, Madār, Darihar, Ghusaut, Tisaut, Karmaha, Naraun, Babhaniyā, Hariam, Sarisab, Sodarpur, Gangolī, Pabaulī, Kujaulī, Ale, Pālī, Sakarāḍhī, Viśe, Phanandaha, Uchit, Pandua, Kataī, Tilāī, Dīgh, Belaunch, Ekahar, Pānichhobh, Baliyās, Jajiwāl, Takwāl and others. Such variations in spelling are themselves evidence of the passage between oral and written forms of genealogical memory.

Mūla Is Not Merely a Geographical "Address"

Several mūlas may belong to a single gotra. Seventy-four branches are mentioned in connection with the Kāśyapa gotra; branches such as Garh and Mangrauni are linked to an ancient point of origin at Mandar. The *bījī puruṣa* is the earliest known male ancestor of such a sub-branch. Here a mūla is not a biological DNA marker but an archival and social identity. This distinction is essential when comparisons are made with modern genetic genealogy.

5. Uṭeḍh, Thirty-Two Ancestors and Sixteen Chhaṭṭhīs: The Arithmetic of Marriage Verification

At the time of a marriage, the pañjīkār would construct a detailed ancestral map of the prospective bride and bridegroom, called in the sources *uṭeḍh*, *uteḍh* or *uṭheḍhā*. Reports describe this as an arrangement encompassing thirty-two ancestral mūlas or forebears. Several accounts relate the number thirty-two to the thirty-two ancestors reached by looking back five generations; others speak of sixteen on the paternal side and sixteen on the maternal side. The practical purpose of the traditional formula is the same: to identify prohibited repetitions of close blood relationships between the two prospective spouses.

Within uṭeḍh, the "sixteen chhaṭṭhīs" form a specialised check. The question-and-answer sources enumerate its kinship points at length: the paternal grandfather's paternal grandfather, the paternal grandfather's maternal grandfather, the paternal grandmother's paternal and maternal grandfathers, the maternal grandfather's paternal and maternal grandfathers, the maternal grandmother's paternal and maternal grandfathers, together with the higher ancestral connections of these branches. In essence, sixteen specific sixth-position ancestors of the bride are compared with the groom's ancestral chart.

The traditional Dharmaśāstric formula refers to excluding five generations on the maternal side and seven on the paternal side. Some pañjī reports say that after the influence of Mahāmahopādhyāya Mahesh Thakur, the practical paternal limit was treated as six generations, making marriage permissible in the seventh. Other reports describe a rule of five maternal plus seven paternal generations for Śrotriyas, and five maternal plus six paternal generations for registered lineages or descendants. The question-and-answer source calls this distinction by status a later social construction and argues that the original Dharmaśāstric rule should apply equally to all. The integrated conclusion is that both the "5/7" ideal and the "5/6" practical modification occur in the source tradition; one cannot silently substitute one for the other.

Principal Prohibitions Governing Marriage Eligibility

The sources give differing lists of four, five or seven rules. As assembled here, the main prohibitions are:

No marriage within the same gotra;

No marriage between those sharing the same pravara;

No marriage within prohibited maternal *sapiṇḍa* relationships;

No marriage within prohibited paternal *sapiṇḍa* relationships;

A special prohibition involving *kāṭhmāmā*, the offspring of the stepmother's brother;

In some interpretations, exclusion of the close descendants of the immediate paternal and maternal grandfathers;

In some social rules, objections to marrying a younger child before an older one, or to marrying the full sister of a wife who is still living.

After completing these checks, the pañjīkār would issue a *siddhānta* or *asvajanya-patra*. The *siddhānta* was understood not simply as an astrologically auspicious time but as certification of genealogical eligibility. "Eligibility" here asks whether the proposed marriage is recognised under the traditional rules of the archive.

A caution concerning genetics: Some reports seek to equate the sixteen chhaṭṭhīs, gotra–pravara and sapiṇḍa rules with "ancient genome mapping" or "chromosome testing." The social purpose of checking "blood distance" is certainly comparable in one respect to modern genetic counselling, but gotra, mūla and pravara are not modern DNA markers. The prohibitions based on the pañjī relied on social and genealogical information; modern genetics relies on biological testing, population data and molecular evidence. The comparison is an analogy, not an identical science.

5a. A Detailed Map of the Sixteen Chhaṭṭhīs and a Practical Example

An extensive source table unpacks the sixteen chhaṭṭhīs as pathways of kinship. Terminology may vary in the records of different pañjīkārs, but the integrated pattern is as follows:

The paternal grandfather of the bride's senior paternal great-great-grandfather;

The father-in-law of that senior paternal ancestor;

The father of the maternal grandfather of the paternal great-grandfather;

The father-in-law of that maternal grandfather;

A senior ancestor on the paternal side of the paternal grandmother;

The maternal grandfather of the bride's father's maternal grandfather;

A senior ancestor on the maternal side of the paternal grandmother;

The maternal grandfather of the paternal grandmother's maternal grandfather;

A senior ancestor on the paternal side of the maternal grandfather;

The maternal grandfather of the maternal great-grandfather;

A senior ancestor on the maternal side of the maternal grandfather;

The maternal grandfather of the maternal grandfather's maternal grandfather;

A senior ancestor on the paternal side of the maternal grandmother;

The maternal grandfather of the maternal grandmother's paternal grandfather;

A senior ancestor on the maternal side of the maternal grandmother;

The maternal grandfather of the maternal grandmother's maternal grandfather.

The list looks simple on paper, but each point requires cross-references between different mūlas, villages and many generations. Some question-and-answer sources define the "maternal side" very strictly: the maternal limit should apply only to relationships arising from the bride's own mother's biological line; female ancestors who entered the paternal line by marriage should not automatically be classified as maternal kin.

Marriage Verification for Shashinath Jha's Daughter

A detailed example constructs the uṭeḍh for a proposed marriage between the daughter of Shashinath Jha of the Karmaha–Behat lineage and a groom residing at Vittho who was likewise connected to Karmaha–Behat. The bride's maternal line was linked with Narayandatta Thakur of Khandbala–Bhaur; the groom's paternal line with Gopinanda Jha of Darihara–Ratauli and others. In the sixteen-chhaṭṭhī comparison, the bride's fourteenth chhaṭṭhī—Kaushilyananda Mishra of Sodarpur–Digaundh—also occurred within the groom's prohibited paternal range. According to the source, this overlap caused the pañjīkār to refuse to issue the *siddhānta-patra*. The significance of the case is that the "chhaṭṭhī" was not an abstract list, but an operative algorithm for deciding marriage eligibility.

Some question-and-answer texts identify a "maternal exception": when the matching chhaṭṭhī occurs solely on the groom's maternal side and is sufficiently remote to fall outside the prohibited five generations, the marriage may be possible. The practical application of this rule requires corroboration from the traditions of different pañjīkārs.

6. Pañjīkārs: Professionals of Memory and Guardians of Archives

A pañjīkār was not merely a "clerk" who read genealogies. His responsibilities included reading old manuscripts, matching references between branches, constructing uṭeḍhs, determining marriage eligibility, adding information about new births and marriages, consulting records in social disputes and safeguarding the manuscripts themselves. Several

reports refer to 185 pañjīs or pañjīkār families. The figure depends on the source, but indicates the breadth of this occupational distribution.

Manuscripts were written in the Mithilākṣara or Tirhutā script on palm leaves, birch bark or other bark, and later handmade paper. Instructions in some accounts describe protection from water, oil and loose or unsuitable bindings; controlled annual exposure to sunlight; wooden covers; tying cords in a knot resembling the *brahmagranthi*; and the use of plant-based inks. Some reports mention a custom of drying the manuscripts in the sun when the sun occupied Leo, approximately August–September. Such instructions should be read as local historical knowledge of archival care, not as substitutes for modern conservation science.

The sources are stern about the ethics of pañjīkārs. They criticise decisions made from private recollection or arbitrary rules without consulting records, excessive fees, fabricated pedigrees and transactions intended to raise social standing. One sentiment quoted in the reports is that the "pañjīkār is a guardian of culture, not a businessman who merely collects fees." This self-criticism matters because the system recognises its own susceptibility to corruption.

6a. Training of Pañjīkārs, the Dhaut Examination and Sabhāgāchhī

Some modern reports describe a tradition, under the patronage of the Darbhanga Raj, in which becoming a pañjīkār required approximately ten years of study and a rigorous test called the *dhaut-parīkṣā*. Scholars who passed received royal recognition; after the end of royal administration, the profession became more concentrated in hereditary families. This is the source's account. Independent archival examination of the institutional history would be useful, but the complexity of the original texts makes clear that pañjīkārs required far more expertise than ordinary clerical skills.

The reports describe public marriage-assembly venues called *sabhāgāchhī* at which genealogies were checked; one source claims there were fourteen royal or traditional sites. Families, pañjīkārs and scholars assembled in mango groves and open grounds, and a *siddhānta-patra* was issued after genealogical scrutiny. The Saurath Assembly is the best-known modern form of this tradition. A sabhāgāchhī was not merely a marketplace in which brides and grooms were sought: it was a forum for public verification of genealogical records, scholarly exchange and social regulation.

6b. Division of Pañjīkārs' Responsibilities and Community-Specific Verification

In the account of Harisinghdev, Gunakar Jha is said to have been appointed principal genealogist for Brahmins, Shankardatta for Karna Kayasthas, and Vijayadatta for Kshatriyas or Gandhawariya Rajputs. The question-and-answer source suggests that Gunakar Jha was chosen because of his earlier learning and regional surveys. The existence of different pañjīkārs for different communities does not necessarily mean that their rules were entirely identical. Even if the fundamental aim of genealogy was shared, gotra, family status, marital conventions and archival forms could differ by community. The surviving record for non-Brahmin pañjīs is described as less secure. The achievements of the available Maithil Brahmin pañjīs should therefore not be mistaken for an equivalent archival record of every caste and community in Mithila.

7. Mithilākṣara, Kaithī–Devanagari and Digital Conversion

Old pañjīs were preserved in the Mithilākṣara or Tirhutā script. Later printed and digitised editions use Devanagari, sometimes Devanagari influenced by Kaithī, or present equivalent material in two columns. Reports on the ancient pañjī, Volume I, and on pages 66–347 both state that the columns convey the same genealogical information: one retains a form closer to the traditional script, while the other offers a more legible Devanagari version.

The decline of knowledge of the script is regarded as a major crisis for the pañjī tradition. As fewer experts can read the manuscripts, families lose the ability to verify their records independently. Digital images, Devanagari transliteration, searchable text, village lists, gotra–mūla indexes and cross-references are proposed as responses. Evidence of digital initiatives after 2000, scanning and publication by 2007–2009, and internal authorial dates such as 2008 indicates a conscious transition from manuscript and paper to digital media.

The sources discuss thousands of images, DVD archives, online publication and printed volumes bearing the title “Genome Mapping.” The advantages of public access are evident: the preservation of lineage memory, easier research and access for migrant communities. There are risks as well: data severed from context, private family information, erroneous automated readings, faulty transliteration from the original script and information detached from the pañjīkār's oral expertise. Sound digitisation should therefore preserve high-quality images, original page numbers, script layers, editorial revision histories, controlled vocabularies, alternative spellings of village names and the pañjīkār's explanations together.

8. Social Categories: Śrotriya, Yogya, Registered Lineages, Vaṃśadhara and Jayawāra

A system of social ranking gradually became attached to the pañjī's original purpose of marriage verification. The reports name categories such as Śrotriya, Yogya, Pañjībaddha/Vaṃśaja, Vaṃśadhara and Jayawāra. Śrotriya denotes a group associated with advanced Vedic learning, ritual discipline and prestigious marital connections; Yogya, a high but subordinate category; Pañjībaddha, a lineage formally recorded in the register; Vaṃśadhara, in some accounts, a branch that has descended from a higher category; and Jayawāra, a designation for families with incomplete records or outside formal ranking. Local names such as *soit*, *jog* and *bhalmānuṣ* appear in some reports.

The sources claim that the earliest pañjī was primarily a means of authenticating lineages, and that rigid social subdivisions of "high" and "low" developed later. They discuss the growth of branch pañjīs, stricter rankings and a prestige-based marriage market during the eighteenth-century reign of Maharaja Madhav Singh. The saying "The pañjī and water flow downwards" came to symbolise the supposed progressive decline in standing when high-ranking families married into lower-ranked ones. The reports also say that the first and second subcategories of the highest Śrotriya grouping disappeared through such processes.

Payments for Higher Rank and Social Distortion

The questions and answers and the reports contain accusations of issuing orders or certificates that "upgraded" genealogical rank in return for money, pressure placed upon pañjīkārs and the buying and selling of social prestige. These allegations cannot be treated as a final finding of fact on the strength of this material alone, but they are recurrent in the collection. The principal point is that the sources themselves recognise the potential influence of wealth and social capital upon a system established to verify genealogical claims.

Some reports also associate the ranking system with multiple marriages by men of high status, the *bikauā* practice, child marriage, dowry and widespread widowhood. They discuss reform attempts in the late nineteenth century, particularly the Sadar Committee of 1876, pledges by pañjīkārs and the wider community, and a claimed tally of 2,289 marriages monitored between 1876 and 1878. These figures should be used as claims made by the sources; independent archival verification remains a subject for future research.

8a. Five Social Tiers of Mūlas, Chaugolā and Pachhabaripār

Some sources classify mūla groups into three principal tiers of prestige—Āyanta Śreṣṭha, Prajāyanta/Varanta and Madhyama. A longer report also presents a five-tier classification associated with Raghudev Jha: Āyanta, Varanta, Madhyama, Adhama and Adhamādhama. The five-tier list is a historical record of social evaluation, not a statement of modern human worth or biological quality. In its source form, it reads:

Āyanta: Khaḍaurai, Khaual, Budhwāl, Madār, Darihara, Ghusaut, Tisaut, Naraun, Karmaha, Babhaniyā, Hariam, Sarisab, Sodarperiyā.

Varanta: Gangolīvar, Pabaulīvar, Kujaulīvar, Alevar, Bahidvār, Sakarāḍhīvar, Pālīvar.

Madhyama: Dīghve, Belaunche, Ekaharai, Pānichhobhe, Baliyāse, Jajiwālai, Takwālai, Pandua, Sakun.

Adhama: Phanandahvar, Dasautīvar, Alariye, Kodariye, Koṭhue, Mahue, Basāvanai.

Adhamādhama: Surganai, Laguḍḍahai, Dahībhaṭāvar, Satalakhai, Uchitivar, Visāivar, Jalaivar.

Spelling varies from report to report; the list above represents a Maithili rendering of the source's phonetic forms. Establishing whether a particular mūla moved between social tiers at different times would require a chronological study of the branch registers.

The Śrotriya "Chaugolā"

One report mentions eight *chaugolā* or ritual levels within the Śrotriya grouping and describes a system of thirty-two registers. Its surviving sample table shows families in the first three levels. The first includes Bharathiyar Jha of Darihara–Ratauli, Bhadai Jha of Pabauli–Badhiyam, Babhan Jha of Sodarpur–Raiyam and Pitambar Jha of Sarisab–Jonki. The second includes Raghuni Jha of Karmaha–Anal, Narayan Jha of Budhwal–Dumra, Debai Jha of Sakaradhi–Parhat and Gangadhar Jha of Khandbala–Bhaur. The third includes Babu Mishra of Sodarpur–Sarisab, Balbhadra Thakur of Khandbala–Bhaur, Tisaut Jha of Tisaut–Kua and Ramdev Mishra of Sodarpur–Raiyam. The reports do not supply the complete list of all eight levels, so only the information available is retained here.

The Fifteen Grades of Pachhabaripār

A source associates Maharaja Rameshwar Singh's arrangement of 1929 with fifteen social grades of *pachhabaripār*, a total of 153 registers, and the prestige designation *laukika*. Examples are: first grade, Narpati Jha

(Sakaradhi–Hardi), Madhav Mishra (Sodarpur–Rohar), Gonu Mishra (Sodarpur–Katka) and Bhaiyan Jha (Budhwal–Dumra); second, Padum Jha, Shrikant Jha and Madhupati Mishra; third, Gahananand Jha; fourth, Chhitri Jha; fifth, Harinarayan Thakur and Sukhai Jha; sixth, Taraiwalla Chaudhary; seventh, Badni Jha; eighth, Bodhkrishna Jha; ninth, Ratikar Jha; tenth, Damodar Jha; eleventh, Manikant Jha; twelfth, Nakat Jha; thirteenth, Ghanshyam Jha; fourteenth, Ghansiram Chaudhary; and fifteenth, Chatur Thakur.

The question-and-answer source interprets this classification with sharply critical attention. It argues that social prestige overwhelmed the pañjī's original purpose of protecting marriages, allegations emerged of advancing rank through royal orders and financial transactions, and *laukika* became a currency of social standing. Independent archival verification of these accusations is necessary; nevertheless, this self-criticism repeatedly emerges within the source material.

9. Dūṣaṇa Pañjī: The Tradition of Recording, Not Erasing, Violations of Rules

The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī is the most complex and uncomfortable document in the pañjī system. The terms *dūṣaṇa* ("blemish") and *kṣaraṇa* ("deterioration") designate departures from an accepted lineage norm as judged by social convention. Remarkably, a system designed to prevent marriages contrary to its rules does not destroy the record of their violation; it enters those violations in its register. The sources regard precisely this paradox as the intellectual importance of the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī.

An analysis of ninety-seven tables classifies many types of entry: relations involving men or women of the leatherworking community (*charmakāra/charmakāriṇī*); relationships with Yavana or Muslim women; descendants of devadāsīs; children of widows; relations involving a teacher's wife; women labelled *path-patitā* ("fallen on the road"); inter-caste marriages; unknown descent or maternal ancestry; unidentified families arriving from western regions; contested connections with Paramabrahmin or Mahāpātra families; branches moving into or out of prestigious social categories; and entries in which the partner's community is not identified but is labelled simply "inter-caste" or "unknown."

Some reports cite cases of full social reintegration after six generations. In the case involving Devdhar, Chamaru and Gangadhar, the descendants of a disapproved marriage are depicted as marrying into recognised mūlas such as Sarisab, Sakaradhi, Panichhobh, Darihara, Pali and Narwal in succeeding generations, eventually recovering a secure position within the community. It is therefore inadequate to call the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī merely a "black book": it chronicles both social exclusion and readmission.

Entries Concerning Muslim/Yavana Women, Devadāsīs and Widows

A Yavana woman named Daulatjahan appears as a maternal ancestor in two tables. She is identified as Dagara's mother and linked with the Nadam/Gangoli–Khaual network. Other entries include one called "Champo Yavana." These examples suggest that boundaries between religious communities were not always as absolute in lived relationships as normative prescriptions imply: such connections occurred and were preserved in the records.

The devadāsī entries are described as a group covering tables 16–21. The mothers of Harihar, "Vidyapati," Lakhu and others are recorded as devadāsīs. One should not automatically assume that the person called "Vidyapati" here is the famous poet of the same name; names recur frequently in the pañjī. Children of widows occur in tables 28 and 94. An expression such as *vārtinī vidhavā* may suggest the woman's social or economic activity, but the determination of its meaning requires caution.

Entries concerning marriage to a "teacher's wife," a woman described as *path-patitā*, an unknown maternal family and inter-caste relationships show that pañjīkārs did not entirely erase inconvenient facts. The language is unquestionably saturated with caste-based value judgments; from a contemporary standpoint, the category of "blemish" demands critical rereading. For historians, however, this very evaluative language reveals structures of social power.

9a. Claims about Health-Related "Defects" in the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī

One extensive report claims that the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī contains genealogical notes about certain health or bodily conditions, as well as departures from social marriage rules. It lists categories such as *apasmārī* (history of epilepsy or convulsions), *unmādī* (described as prolonged mental disturbance) and *ākuñjī* (a grouping described as encompassing blindness, deafness, congenital lameness and other bodily differences). The boundaries of these categories cannot be established without a page-specific critical edition of the original Dūṣaṇa Pañjī.

The discovery of such records would have historical importance because it would suggest that families attended to the recurrence of health characteristics over generations. It would nonetheless be wrong to call this "ancient medical genomics" or to equate it with modern genetics and the study of hereditary disease. Epilepsy, mental illnesses, blindness and mobility impairments can have genetic and non-genetic causes; the pañjī contained no clinical testing. Its health-related notes should be read as historical social and medical observations.

Further Examples of Dūṣaṇa and Reintegration

A source enumerates "unapproved" or "unknown" marriages among several branches and their subsequent status: an unidentified-caste woman in the Devsharma branch of Pali; an unidentified woman in the Govind branch of Budhwal; an unidentified woman in the Shrinath branch of Sarisab; a marriage of this kind followed by middle-tier status in the Bhim branch of Darihara; a division of branches in the Shrihari branch of Sodarpur; reintegration after several generations in the Vasudev branch of Hariam; monitoring through the maternal line in the Madhukar branch of Panichhobh; "purification" after the sixth generation in the Bhavnath branch of Sarisab; the Yavana woman Daulatjahan in the Dagara branch of Gangoli; a relationship between the Surpati branch of Khandbala–Bhaur and Sohago, daughter of a Koch Rajbanshi king of Assam; Medha, identified as a woman of the leatherworking community, in the Govind branch of Sodarpur; and a relationship with the Hadi community in the Hadini branch. The vocabulary of this list reflects the social judgments of the period represented by the source. The integrated essay preserves it as evidence of historical classification, not as a valid modern evaluation of these relationships.

10. The Gangesha Upadhyaya Episode: Genealogy, Philosophy and Controversy

The strongest claim in the reports on the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī concerns Gangesha Upadhyaya, the founder of Navya-Nyāya. Citing tables 49–51, entries 188/2, 189/1 and 189/2, and references to the Mūla Pañjī, a report states that Gangesha's wife Vallabha came from the Charmakāriṇī community. Some readings quote an old marginal note saying that Gangesha was born five years after his father's death. The reports also discuss his son Vardhamana, Supan/Harisharma, and subsequent genealogical links involving Gora, Bhaveshwara and others.

On the basis of this archival material, the reports allege that some twentieth-century scholars suppressed information concerning Gangesha's family background or the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī. The names appearing in the controversy include Dineshchandra Bhattacharya, author of a history of Navya-Nyāya, information supplied by Ramanath Jha, and Udayanath Jha "Ashok." The responsibility of the present integrated essay is to preserve the accusations as accusations in the source reports. Without an independent examination of the archival evidence, it would be inappropriate to deliver a final historical judgment that anyone engaged in deliberate suppression.

Gangesha's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* is a foundational text of the Navya-Nyāya tradition. The report connects his titles of *Jagadguru* and *Paramaguru*

with the scholarship of Vardhamana, the spread of Navya-Nyāya from Mithila towards Navadvipa, Vasudeva's studies, Pakshadhara Mishra, Raghunatha Shiromani and related matters. Two histories meet within this account: the intellectual history of a philosophical text and the social history of its author's family.

The source also mentions publication of a Maithili story entitled *Śabdaśāstram* and its English translation, drawing on this material. This demonstrates that genealogical records can themselves become literary sources. When the pañjī preserves an unexpected social fact, a modern author can shape it into fiction, criticism or alternative history.

10a. Fine Distinctions between Source Readings in the Gangesha Episode

Copies of the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī files and the reports based upon them are not entirely consistent. One principal report records Gangesha's Vallabha as a *charmakāriṇī* in table 49, entry 188/2; table 50, entry 189/1 separately records the lengthy lineage of another woman, Medha Charmakāriṇī. A later report identifies Medha as Gangesha's mother, but a close reading of the relevant Dūṣaṇa Pañjī text does not regard this identification as decisive. The integrated conclusion of the present work, based on the reading of entry 188/2, is explicit: Gangesha was born five years after the death of his father, and he married Vallabha Charmakāriṇī. The later, conflicting interpretation concerning Medha is retained only as a source's view, not as a settled biographical fact.

An entry numbered 339/3 in the Devananda Pañjī gives a multigenerational sequence involving Supan/Harisharma, his son Haraditya, daughter Gora and connections with Jajiwal/Sandagahi; entry 30/5 records a Khandbala connection involving Vardhamana's daughter. The reports present such material as evidence inconsistent with claims that Gangesha's lineage "immediately ended." Allegations against twentieth-century scholars of "suppressing information" appear in the reports; reaching a historical judgment on them would require examining original correspondence, editions, available records and the chronology of publication.

10b. Source Claims Concerning Aryabhata, Chaitanya and Other Famous Figures

One detailed report claims to connect Aryabhata's family line with Trinayan Bhatta, the founding male ancestor of the Mandar–Mangrauni branch, and supplies a fifteen-generation sequence: Trinayan Bhatta, Udaybhatta, Vijaybhatta, Sulochan, Bhatta, Dharma-jati Mishra, Dhara-jati Mishra, Brahmaraj Mishra, Tripurajati Mishra, Vidhujati Mishra, Ajay Singh, Vijay Singh, Adivaraha, Mahavaraha, Duryodhan Singh and

Mahāmahopādhyāya Narasimha. The report associates this sequence with Aryabhata's family background, but accepting such an identification without independent examination of names, dates and contemporary external evidence would be unsafe. This essay preserves it only as a genealogical claim of the source report.

The same report claims a spiritual or scholarly connection with Chaitanya Mahaprabhu through Rampati Upadhyaya of the Vatsa gotra and Karmaha–Tarauni branch, also called Vishnupuri or Paramanandapuri. It is essential to distinguish "biological descent" from a "teacher–disciple lineage." Even if the pañjī supplies Rampati Upadhyaya's family, it does not thereby establish Chaitanya's blood ancestry. At most, it provides a line of inquiry into contacts between the wider bhakti movement and scholars of Mithila.

The same rule should govern entries associated with famous names—Aryabhata, Vidyapati, Jyotirishwar, Gangesha and Ganganath: similarity of names is an initial clue, not proof of identity.

II. Women, Maternal Descent and the Silences of the Pañjī

The pañjī is fundamentally patrilineal in structure. Its principal sequence of names proceeds from father to son, while gotra and mūla also depend on paternal identity. At first glance, therefore, women appear almost absent. Yet the actual arithmetic of marriage verification cannot operate without women. The *dau/ddau* designation, maternal village, maternal grandfather's side, the five maternal *sapiṇḍa* generations and the sixteen chhaṭṭhīs all make maternal connections indispensable to the archive. A woman's name may remain unwritten, but without her genealogical position no decision on marriage eligibility is possible.

This paradox may be described as "structural presence and nominal absence." The bride's father's name, her maternal village, the mūla of her maternal grandfather and the ancestral lines of her grandmothers were necessary for verifying marriage; information about women's relations therefore forms a central link in the network. The male-centred style of the main text suppresses their visibility. The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī, asvajanya-patras, marriage colophons, branches referring to a second wife as *aparā* and modern occupational entries open cracks in this silence.

Some sources claim that the names of women were systematically recorded in special asvajanya-patras associated with the Rasaḍh–Araria region. Modern nagarām pañjīs contain such expressions as "wife Anita" and "first IAS daughter." By contrast, many women in the principal genealogical lines remain "the daughter from such-and-such village." Taken together, these forms of evidence do not mean that the pañjī was a "feminist" archive, nor that women were entirely absent from it. The appropriate

conclusion is that marriage regulation led the pañjī to retain data on maternal descent, while social prestige and naming practices remained centred upon men.

Women's Bodies as Social Boundaries in the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī

Women identified as charmakāriṇī, Yavana, devadāsī, widow, a teacher's wife, *path-patitā* or of unknown lineage recur among the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī's categories; many entries make the woman's social condition the vehicle of a genealogical "blemish." The language is itself a record of the caste-based, patriarchal morality of its time. Yet historians must also recognise something equally important: women whom the principal, laudatory genealogy might have omitted survived in the archive precisely because of the supposed "blemish," either by name or by recorded connection. In modern research, the archive's stigmatising category can therefore be turned into a source for the social history of marginalised people.

Marriage, Widowhood and Polygamy

Reports on social ranking, demand for high-status bridegrooms and *bikauā* polygamy demonstrate the pañjī system's indirect consequences for women's lives. Colophons record four, five, six or more marriages by certain men; in extreme examples, some reports mention as many as twelve. The history involved is not merely one of male prestige, but also of the widowhood of many women, child marriage, financial transactions and inequality within families. Reform initiatives such as the Sadar Committee were therefore not external incidents in the history of the pañjī: they were responses to its social consequences.

12. The Ancient Pañjī, Volume I: Pages 1–65 — Foundations of Genealogical Grammar

The first sixty-five pages of Volume I of the Ancient Pañjī provide a primary text for understanding the "grammar" of the pañjī. Its opening formula, "atha patra pañjī likhyate" ("now the genealogical register is written"), establishes the formal character of the record. Personal names, fathers, sons, mūlas, villages, dau designations, alternative names, scholarly titles and maternal-lineage cycles are compressed into brief formulae. According to the report's count, this part records at least 122 named villages, 17 active gotras, more than 55 maternal-lineage cycles, approximately 47 Mahāmahopādhyāyas and thousands of individuals. The figure of "approximately five thousand persons" is an estimate in the source report; an independent recount of the original would be useful.

Halāyudha of Gaṅgaulī: A Historical Point of Reference

Among the notable genealogical sequences in the first volume, Halāyudha of Gaṅgaulī occupies an important position. The report considers the possibility that he was the scholar Halāyudha associated with the reign of Ballāla Sena of Bengal, placing the chronology approximately in the latter part of the twelfth century. Names such as Vīra, Nārāyaṇa and Śūlapāṇi occur among his descendants. Sibling-order signs such as "05/04" show that the pañjī recorded not only direct descent but also a person's position among brothers. The problem of identical names among historical individuals arises here as well. Identification must therefore be tested against gotra, mūla, village, generation and contemporary context.

Mahāmahopādhyāyas and the Geography of Knowledge

The source report particularly emphasises the concentration of scholars bearing the title Mahāmahopādhyāya in the Khauāl–Sarisab–Khaṇḍbalā region. Distinctions in grammar, Nyāya, astrology, Vedic studies and Dharmaśāstra are entered alongside family genealogies. A lineage associated with a scholar named Narasiṃha is claimed to demonstrate the continuation of scholarship over eighteen generations. This makes the pañjī an alternative source for intellectual history: it preserves traces of family-based traditions of learning that fall outside university records and official lists.

Royal Offices and Administration

Offices such as that of Devāditya, described as a "śāntivigrahika," together with royal honours, religious jurisdictions, treasurial and court-related titles, show that the pañjī is not merely a list of Brahmanical ritual specialists. The relationship between government administration and scholarly families also becomes part of genealogy. Such titles make it possible to reconstruct elements of the political order, royal patronage and the role of educated groups at particular historical moments.

Unusual Entries

The entry for Kāmadeva, a student of all four Vedas, in association with "Ḍom Ṭekarī" reveals the complexities of social boundaries and occupational or community designations. A title such as "Ayācī" points to an ascetic ideal of not soliciting gifts. Remarks concerning "tegachhiyā" or an attenuated branch are especially significant: in these instances the pañjī itself acknowledges that information about a branch had become incomplete or that memory had been broken. The register is therefore not an omniscient, error-free database. It also records the loss of knowledge.

Maternal-Lineage Cycles

References to more than fifty-five maternal-lineage cycles associated with names such as Śrīdhara, Sore, Gaṅgādhara and Baidyanātha reveal the density of the marriage network. Parallel to the main patrilineal sequence, recurring circles of maternal connections link a family to many villages and mūlas. The geography of the pañjī is, in effect, the geography of marriage.

The Colophon of 1856 CE

An important colophon gives the date Śaka 1778, the third day of the dark fortnight of Śrāvaṇa—approximately 1856 CE. A scribe or copyist named Rāmānanda of Paṇḍuā, a reference to Gaṇeśa, son of Lakṣmīdhara, and a note on copying establish that older genealogical material continued to be recopied and preserved in the nineteenth century. The date at which a manuscript was written and the date at which a lineage recorded within it began are therefore different matters.

12a. Ṣaḍyantrī Scholars, the Vaśaiṭhī Inscription and Rajput Clans: Additional Evidentiary Leads

A detailed report explains "ṣaḍyantrī" as denoting a tradition of scholars proficient in six śāstras or philosophical systems, and lists thirteen names: Mahāmahopādhyāya Godhī Śarmā, Mādhava Śarmā, Ādya Mādhava Śarmā, Śaṅkara Śarmā, Yajñapati Śarmā, Paraśurāma Śarmā, Vāmadeva Śarmā, Pītāmbara Śarmā Vidyānidhi, Gokulanātha Śarmā of Phanandah, Jagannātha Śarmā of Phanandah, Vaṃśadhara Śarmā of Rājanpurā–Dariharā, Raghunātha Śarmā of Phanandah, and Upādhyāya Datta/Viṣṇudatta Śarmā Paramānandapurī. The available source supplies this list; the particular scholarly works and dates associated with each name still require comparison with independent textual evidence.

The same report claims that a temple inscription in the Vaśaiṭhī/Araria region contains an account of seven generations of Queen Indravatī of the Suragan–Loām royal family corresponding to the pañjī genealogy. If the original inscription or a reliable transcription is available, it could furnish an excellent example of independent external verification of a genealogical record. The present integrated essay retains the claim as a research lead; without inspecting the inscription directly, it does not treat the correspondence as conclusively confirmed.

The report's assertion that the Varṇaratnākara mentions sixty-two Rajput clans also points towards the broader society of Mithila. Comparative research is needed into the archival traditions of Kṣatriyas, Karṇa Kāyasthas, Rajputs and other communities beyond the Brahmin-centred material presently available in the pañjī studies.

13. Expansion of Volume I: Pages 66–347 — The Karmahā Centre, the Nepal Corridor and Contemporary Marriages

Across pages 66–347, the pañjī abruptly ceases to look like a static "ancient" document: it emerges as a living register. The name Karmahā occurs approximately 292 times in the source count, signalling a geographical shift from the Maṇḍar-centred landscape of the earlier part. Rataulī–Dariharā–Khauāl, Taraunī, Dumrā, Gaṅgorā, Kanhaulī, Mahiṣī, Lohanā, Jagaur, Jhanjhārpur and numerous places near Nepal form new networks.

The Rataulī–Dariharā–Karmahā Triangle

The Rataulī–Dariharā subgroup and the Karmahā–Khauāl connections reveal a north-eastern extension of centres of learning and marriage. A list of villages is not simply a map: the more frequently a village appears as a maternal village, ancestral village, present residence or marital connection, the greater its social "centrality." In this sense, the pañjī becomes a fine-grained social map of medieval Mithila.

"Avalamba–Sarasvatī–Dāṅkita" and New Scholarly Titles

The source report identifies a rare title, "Avalamba–Sarasvatī–Dāṅkita Mahāmahopādhyāya," associated with Baṭeśa Puruṣottama, son of Hariśvara. Paradoxical epithets such as "Sarvajña Garīb," Vedic sub-branches, designations such as pāṃ/pañca associated with scholarly families, and the prefix Ṭhākur reveal multiple strata of naming culture. A title in the pañjī is not merely an ornament: it becomes a historical label for a family's intellectual occupation and standing.

The Integration of Mahārāja Mādhava Siṃha

The entry for Mahārāja Mādhava Siṃha, with his extended titulature, places the royal family within the ordinary dau formulas and marriage network. The king's genealogy is not segregated into a special "royal appendix" outside the rules of the pañjī; like other families, it is incorporated into the lines of relationship. This reveals an interdependence between royal legitimacy and Brahmanical genealogical records. Separate entries for Mādhava Siṃha's sons extend this integration.

Traces of Mughal Administration

The designation "cāturmāsika mansabdār hazārī" attached to Rāmānanda Chaudharī Maṇikānandana exemplifies the entrance of Mughal administrative vocabulary into local genealogies. Read alongside later titles such as "Rāy," "Rājā" and "Mahārājā," the pañjī becomes a nominal record of changes in political authority.

Bhauālvāsī: Migration towards Nepal

An entry reading "Bhauālvāsī" is interpreted as indicating a migrant branch associated with the Kathmandu Valley or Bhauāl in Nepal. The network of Simarāvāṛ, Maliṅgiyā–Kujolī and frontier villages captures historical movement between Mithila and Nepal at the level of genealogical records. Long before the formation of modern national borders, families commonly moved for marriage, education and service.

Marriages in 2003–2004: An Extraordinary Compression of Time

The most striking feature of this part is its dated modern marriage colophons: 1 December 2003, 9 December 2003, 15 December 2003, 20 January 2004, 21 December 2004, and others. The source report counts more than twenty-four such entries. Their appearance within ancient genealogical sequences demonstrates that the pañjī was not "dead" history but a legal and social instrument being continually updated. A medieval scholar, an eighteenth-century king and a twenty-first-century marriage can occupy the same page—a phenomenon the report describes as "temporal compression."

A Caution concerning the Name "Poet Vidyāpati"

A later entry explicitly contains the words "kavi Vidyāpati." Yet names recur frequently in the pañjī; finding the name Vidyāpati alone does not establish identity with the celebrated Maithili poet Vidyāpati Ṭhākur. Correct identification requires agreement on mūla, village, father, generation, date and related branch. The importance of this example lies in the methodological discipline it teaches regarding personal identification.

14. Volume II: Pages 348–690 — The Pañjī Encounters Modern India

On pages 348–690 of Volume II, the centre of gravity shifts again. According to the source count, Sodarpur appears approximately 853 times, Maṇḍar 621 times and Karmahā 580 times. The frequency of a village name is not simply a population measure; it combines marriage ties, prominent families and references to branches. In this volume, the pañjī readily incorporates the administration of colonial and independent India, universities, marriages abroad, modern degrees and professions.

From Mādhava Siṃha to Kāmeśvara Siṃha

The genealogy of the Darbhanga Raj develops from Mādhava Siṃha to Kāmeśvara Siṃha as an extended royal sequence. The source report draws attention to the imperial distinction "K.C.I.E." and an academic indication such as "Litt." in Kāmeśvara Siṃha's entry. The older "Mahārājādhirāja" and newer colonial honours converge in a single

person's labels. At the level of nomenclature, this is a compressed history of political change.

Interreligious Marriage in Sweden and Intercaste Marriage

Entries recording an "interreligious marriage" in Sweden and, separately, an "intercaste marriage" are striking examples of the pañjī system's modern adaptation. Significantly, the genealogical sequence does not end after such marriages. A note is added in parentheses or as an annotation, and descendants continue to be entered. This resembles a modern echo of the older logic of the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī: a departure from the norm or a new social event does not terminate the archive but becomes new information within it.

Abhinava-Sarasvatī and the Modern University

Traditional scholarly titles such as "Abhinava-Sarasvatī" continue to survive, while a professor or grammarian in the Maithili department of Calcutta University, modern educated professionals, government officers and advocates enter the pañjī alongside them. Mahiṣī emerges as a subsidiary centre of learning. The report reads its longstanding philosophical reputation in relation to the memory of Maṇḍana Miśra, although particular claims of genealogical identity require independent verification.

The Rāy Families: From Mughal to British Administration

The title "Rāy" is said to occur approximately fifty-three times in this volume. From a Mughal-era revenue or administrative distinction into the colonial period, the same title continues to mark a family's social identity. The pañjī reveals the "longue durée" of political history within names: rulers change, but local markers of prestige survive through reinterpretation.

The Poets Jīvakarṇa and "Madhurakavi" Māghava

Explicit literary designations such as poet Jīvakarṇa and "Madhurakavi Māghava" make the pañjī a supplementary source for the literary history of Maithili. These entries cannot, by themselves, establish a catalogue of works. They do, however, provide a basis for investigating the social identity of a "poet," the relevant village and family, marriage ties and possible chronology.

The Expansion of Marriage Colophons

Volume II discusses approximately forty-one dated marriage colophons, ranging from the later nineteenth century to September 2004. Some men are recorded as having married four to six times. The social significance is

not merely that the register is "rich in data": these entries supply material for studying polygamy, widowhood, remarriage, family strategies and the stratified marriage market.

Urban Markers

Combined designations of residence such as "Rājā Rāmlocana (Katihar)," "Kolkata (Pālī)" and "Sanhavāsī Karmahā" transform the supposedly fixed meaning of the ancestral village. A family retains its attachment to its mūla while settling in a city for reasons of occupation or politics. The pañjī thus points towards the need to distinguish "ancestral origin" from "residence," a particularly important distinction when constructing a modern digital database.

15. Upaṭīpa and the "Genome Pañjī": Short Treatises on Descent

Sources entitled "Pañjī-Prabandha," "Upaṭīpa" or "Uṭipa" continually unfold genealogies into fine branches. Viewed in isolation, a short entry may look like a heap of names. Once its signs of relationship are joined together, it becomes a network connecting many families through marriages, maternal villages, offices, migration, teaching and royal service.

A Patrilineal Backbone, a Bilateral Marriage Network

The principal lineage is a father-to-son sequence, but at every "dau" or "ddau" the maternal family enters the record. It is therefore incomplete to describe the pañjī as a "purely patrilineal genealogy." Its genealogical backbone is patrilineal; its marriage network is bilateral. In contemporary network analysis, a person can be represented as a node, the father–son line as one kind of relationship, and marriage and the maternal village as other kinds of relationship.

The Khaṇḍbalā Siṃha Family: A Social Bridge

Some reports discuss the Khaṇḍbalā Siṃha family as a non-Brahmin social bridge, describing it in some places as resembling Bhūmihārs and elsewhere as resembling Kāyasthas. The terminology is not consistent across the sources, so no definite caste identification can be made without rereading the original pañjī. Nevertheless, one point is clear: the pañjī network is not merely a practical picture of a closed endogamous circle. It also contains records of external marital relationships in particular periods and families.

The Loām–Sugaunā Rāy Family

In the Loām–Sugaunā section, references to Chandra Nārāyaṇa Rāy, Rājā Devanārāyaṇa and later generations in modern administrative service demonstrate long-term social mobility. The modern IAS officer Naresh

Chandra appears at one end of this sequence in the source. Here the pañjī traces occupational change from a locally prominent family into the modern all-India administrative services.

The Kṣatriya/Ṭhākur Families of Bhaur–Rājgrām

The Ṭhākur/Kṣatriya families of Bhaur–Rājgrām, including Kṛṣṇa Siṃha, open an associated archival world beyond the principal Brahmin-centred pañjī tradition. Narratives of early institutionalisation describe Guṇākara Jhā as a genealogist for Brahmins, Śaṅkaradatta for Karṇa Kāyasthas, and Vijayadatta for Kṣatriyas or the Gandhavāriyā group. Modern surviving material is uneven; the sources express concern that some non-Brahmin genealogical traditions have diminished or disappeared.

Navya-Nyāya and Educated Lineages

The title "Naiyāyika," the distinction Mahāmahopādhyāya, identifications such as "Sir Gaṅgānātha," Ācārya Rāmnātha, M.A., Ph.D., and Professor Tantranātha make the pañjī a social map of intellectual traditions. The identification of "Sir Gaṅgānātha" with Gaṅgānātha Jhā is considered possible, but when an original entry supplies insufficient particulars, the equation should remain a possibility rather than a conclusion.

The Internal Date of 9 July 2008

A colophon dated in the month of Āṣāḍha, on Wednesday, 9 July 2008, marks the period of digital editing. Such dates clarify the different layers of a source: the genealogical matter may be centuries old, the manuscript copy nineteenth- or twentieth-century, and the digital edition twenty-first-century. A critical edition must keep metadata for these three periods separate.

The Use of the Word "Genome"

With a title such as "Genome Mapping, 450–2009 CE," the textual project gives the pañjī's extensive genealogical information a modern metaphor. The metaphor has considerable force: long-term family networks, marriage distances, population history and patterns of migration can all be mapped. Its limit is equally clear: the pañjī contains no biological samples, DNA sequences, chromosome tests or statistical genetic validation. "Genome" in this project should therefore be understood as a metaphor or aspiration for cultural-genealogical mapping, not as a direct claim to modern molecular genomics.

16. Nagarām, Volume III: The Entry of Modern Professions into Village Groups

The Nagarām pañjī is organised into village-based sections. Each block begins with a formula such as "Nagarām" or "grāmārambha" ("beginning of the village"), an invocation of a deity, and then names of persons, sut/sutā relations, villages, dau/ddau designations and reciprocal codes. Because of this organisation, the whole text can be read as a social map.

The Unstable Spellings of Village Names

The same village appears on different pages under phonetic, Sanskritised or scribe-specific spellings. The source report estimates some sixty to eighty variant forms requiring normalisation. A digital edition should not impose one "standard name" by erasing the original wording. The original spelling, standard modern form, district or block, and geographical identification should be stored in separate fields.

Sandahpur–Siśpur: Formal and Familiar Names

In the early blocks, a formal name for an individual or a village is found alongside "pra." or a familiar local name, such as Āṅkhī or Naharā. This double-name system preserves the reality of identification in an oral society. Without both the documentary name and the household or village name, personal identification may be incomplete.

Khāṅguṛ–Padahiyā: "Yantrajña"

The designation "yantrajña" in block 33 is interpreted as an early sign of modern engineering or technical occupations. Amid traditional Mahāmahopādhyāyas, astrologers and grammarians, a profession involving the knowledge of machines demonstrates that the pañjī continued to register occupational change.

Kanhaulī–Maṅgraunī: A Judge, an IAS Officer and a Communist Member of Parliament

Within the single network of relations in block 122 appear Justice Amarnātha, Professor Trilokanātha, IAS, references to a Communist MP or the CPI(M), and traditional connections to a grammarian's family by marriage. The modern state, left-wing politics and classical scholarship are present in the same familial network. Here the pañjī does not take a political position; it records relationships.

Raiyām–Rājahaṛā: University Families

In block 148, the Mahāmahopādhyāya tradition is joined by a former vice-chancellor of Allahabad University, Dr Umeśa, Professor Jayakānta, a

historian of Maithili literature, Professor Kṛṣṇakānta, a geologist, and others, forming a dense cluster of educated people. The genealogical inheritance of learning changes its form here, moving from classical scholarly titles towards modern university specialisations.

Rohar–Bhavānīpur: Political Lineages

The family of Chaudharī Baccū and its regional political influence in block 183 show that modern democratic politics, too, has become part of genealogical memory. Suffixes such as "Kiśora," "Nārāyaṇa" and "Indra" in the names reveal generational preferences in naming.

Three Periods of Occupation

The Nagarām report views the long-term transformation of occupational titles in three broad periods. The first comprises Vedic learning, Nyāya, grammar, astrology, Dharmaśāstra and the Mahāmahopādhyāya title. The second comprises colonial law, advocates, judicial posts, revenue administration, railways and technical services. The third comprises professors, scientists, engineers, physicians, IAS and IPS officers, Members of Parliament and judges in independent India. This progression should not be treated as a set of rigid chronological boundaries, but as a useful indication of social and occupational change.

A Chronology of Naming Practices

The sources describe an early predominance of Śiva-associated names ending in "Nātha," "Īśvara" and "Śaṅkara"; the popularity of "Nārāyaṇa" and "Kṛṣṇa" in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries; "Chandra," "Mohan," "Bahādur" and "Rāy" in the colonial period; and the increasing occurrence of "Kumār" and shorter modern names in the twentieth century. These linguistic data make the pañjī a rare long-term repository for onomastics.

Migration

Families spread from the Madhubani–Darbhanga centre towards Purnia–Banailī, Muzaffarpur, Bhagalpur–Munger, Saharsa–Supaul, Champaran, the Nepal Tarai, Kathmandu, and later metropolitan and national administrative centres. The ancestral village remains an identifying point, but residence and occupation change. The pañjī is thus not only a narrative of "fixed caste"; it is also a narrative of mobile populations and migration.

17. Pañjikā–Nagarāmī, Blocks 226–352: Familiar Names, Degrees and Occupational Lineages

In this section of Nagarāmī, genealogy becomes a miniature encyclopaedia of modern social history. Alongside personal names, the entries

increasingly mention household names, professions, degrees, universities, courts, government employment and even the professional achievements of daughters. The traditional formula is not abandoned; new fields of information are added within it.

The Branches of Maṅgaunī, Hāṭī and Samaulī

Block 226 follows the Devakīnandana line from Maṅgaunī to Madarī; blocks 226–227 the Vaṃśamaṇi sub-branch; block 228 the lines of brothers; and blocks 230–232 the Hāṭī–Satalakhā/Vilakhinad connections, all in successive compact formulae. The entry for Chānurā Jhā Haridāsa Jhā shows the coexistence of familiar and formal names. The importance of this material lies not only in "great personalities," but in the continuous recombination of smaller branches.

Samaulī: The Cultural Diversity of Names

Block 238 records Pradyumna's sons Rājīvalocana, Kamala and Ghoghana; block 244 includes Nīlāmbara, Mahīpati and Upe, alongside popular names such as Sanāphūl, Phekana and Choṭā. Long Sanskritic names, devotional names, names derived from flowers or nature, nicknames and shortened household names occur within the same family. The pañjī records a living culture of names, not merely their "standard" linguistic forms.

Balirājpur–Choptā: Education and Engineering

Block 253 contains the family of Buvuājī/Jayakṛṣṇa: Kumārjī, Amarnātha, Pītāmbara/Naval Kiśora, Jagadīśa and Satyanārāyaṇa; and, among Naval Kiśora's sons, Professor Śyāmānanda, engineer Manoj Kumār and Subodh Kumār, forming a clear sequence of modern occupational change. In block 254, "Sāhityācārya Professor Dr Viśvambhara Miśra 'Vāgīśa'" combines in one identity the traditional distinction Sāhityācārya, the modern university titles "professor" and "doctor," and a literary pen name.

Indicators of Dates and Degrees

A formula such as "1934, third M.A." is a chronological marker of the moment when a modern university degree came to be regarded as a detail worth preserving in genealogy. Double M.A. degrees, engineers, pleaders or advocates, income-tax service and commissions now become a new language of family prestige. The older Mahāmahopādhyāya title does not vanish; newer degrees grow alongside it.

Advocate Families and the Legal Profession

The family of advocate Brajamohana in block 307—with Narendramohana, M.S., a principal, a law faculty and other lawyers—

reveals the intergenerational expansion of legal professions under colonial and postcolonial conditions. The pañjī makes possible close study of how occupational capital persists or changes across generations.

The Explicit Identification of a Maithili Writer

Block 316 expressly records Dr Professor Vedanātha as a "writer in the Maithili language." This is especially significant for literary history: a person's creative identity has itself entered the family register. Such an entry could provide a model for verifying the identities of other poets and authors.

An IPS–IAS Family and a Daughter

In blocks 345–346, entries for Mahāvīra, IPS and DIG, and his sons Arun/Amit, IAS, display the prestige of the modern all-India services. Particularly noteworthy is the reference to the "first IAS daughter," an exceptional moment in which a woman's professional achievement is recorded in the genealogical text. The exception itself shows that professional identification of women was not the ordinary rule; yet, as social values changed, the criteria governing archival selection could change as well.

A "Jury" Member of the Calcutta High Court

Block 347 mentions "Pāṭaka Bauna" as a member of a jury of the Calcutta High Court, leaving a trace of local social history under the colonial judicial system. Such brief indications of office in the pañjī may provide leads for locating formal government records.

The Deep Lineage of Hariam

Block 352 brings together the five sons of Paśupati, all with names ending in "-pati," prestigious maternal connections such as Sarisab and Belaunch, and an extensive generational sequence. Such an entry connects three fields at once: naming conventions, marital prestige and the expansion of genealogical branches.

18. Nagarām, Blocks 359–466: From Invocations of Deities to Royal Houses and Modern Officials

Almost every block in this section consists of an invocation of a deity, the word "grāmārambha," genealogical formulae and reciprocal codes. The source report interprets the abundance of Śiva or Śaiva names in the openings as possible indicators of family deities or local religious memory. This interpretation is plausible; however, before treating each divine name as necessarily referring to a family deity, the underlying tradition and local evidence must be examined.

Vicāṛhī–Kuā and Parahaṭ–Chānpurā

The Vicāṛhī–Kuā group in blocks 359–362 shows the underlying structure of many generations, maternal relationships and changes of village. In blocks 363–367, the Parahaṭ–Chānpurā sequence joins religious, scholarly and royal prestige within one genealogical network through distinctions such as Mahāmahopādhyāya Khageśa, "Rājā Vidyānidhi Hṛdayanidhi," and Dhīrendra, a performer of four-part ritual sacrifice.

Maṅgaurī–Khojpur: Dense Scholarly Families

Blocks 370–376 contain an extensive sequence of scholars centred on the ascetic Upādhyāya Rāmabhadra: Paṇḍitarāja, Mahāmahopādhyāya Madhusūdana, Mahāmahopādhyāyas Baidyanātha and Pītāmbara, Umānanda, Mahāmahopādhyāya Vāgīśa and others. This is the social history of a "family of learning." Scholarship may be not only individual talent but a collective ecology of teaching culture, books, teachers, marriage networks and patronage.

Pilakhavāṛ–Maṅgaurī and Alay–Lagmā

Blocks 379–382 continue the branch of Mahāmahopādhyāya Vāgīśa. In the Alay–Lagmā corridor in blocks 383–387, the concentration of names ending in "Datta" forms a distinctive subgroup for onomastic study. Naming patterns within a family can be informal supplementary clues to genealogical identification, but names alone cannot establish a relationship of descent.

The Baiganī–Baṃsī Royal Family

In blocks 388–395, the Baiganī/Baṃsī royal line, connections with Banailī/Rāmgaṛh, Rājā Kīrtyānanda Siṃha Bahādur and musical distinctions open a history of modern royal and cultural patronage. The royal household is joined to the pañjī through marriage relationships, making the register a genealogical source for local political history.

Paramgaṛh–Piṇḍāruc and the Chaudharī Families

In blocks 392–398, the Chaudharī families, modern names containing "Kumār" or "Chandra," and regional prestige illustrate a transitional form of social change. This is neither wholly the era of classical scholarly titles nor an exclusively modern world of professional identities; the two are intermingled.

Jagatpur–Oin: The Simraungarh Royal Line

Blocks 402–406 supply an extended eulogistic sequence for the royal line associated with Oin/Oinhā. The report notes names such as Rājā-Paṇḍit Kāmeśvara, Rājā Bhogīśvara, Mahāmahattaka Kusumeśvara and

Mahārājādhirāja Bhaveśvara/Bhavasiṃha, as well as an ancient date, Śaka 768—approximately 846 CE. Such very early dates must be used with extreme caution. They matter as claims within the pañjī tradition, but cannot be accepted as definitive historical facts without independent scrutiny through epigraphy, contemporary inscriptions and texts, and the chronology of genealogical generations.

Nahas–Khauāl: From Scholars to IAS and IPS Officers

In blocks 420–428, families of astrologers and classical scholars are connected to later members of the modern administrative services. This transition illustrates the long-term value of the pañjī: the "occupation of knowledge" changes within a lineage, while social capital flows into new institutions—universities, courts and the bureaucracy.

Chānpurā, Sukhait–Pilakhavāṛ and Peripheral Groups

The social group of Chānpurā in blocks 429–434, the line of Mahāmahopādhyāya Nenā at Sukhait–Pilakhavāṛ in blocks 447–450, philosophical names such as "Jñānī" and "Dhyānī," and the Parahaṭ, Satalakhā, Munger, Lohanā, Rohar and Supaul/Nepal-border areas in blocks 451–466 extend the central geography of the pañjī. For this section, the source report estimates eight to twelve generations on average, in some cases fifteen to eighteen, more than three thousand individuals and over two hundred villages. These are estimates based on the report; they can be checked through digital counting.

The Frequency of Maternal Villages

In this selected portion, the source report identifies high frequencies for Sodarpur, Darbharā, Pālī, Belaunch, Khauāl, Karmahā, Jajivāl, Sarisab, Pabausal, Maṇḍar and Ekahar, among others. If machine-assisted verification against the original pages confirms these frequencies, they may provide a firm basis for identifying the "central villages" in the marriage network.

19. Purnia and the Social Geography of Eastern Mithila

A separate report links the discussion of the pañjī with the local histories of Purnia, Asaṅgā, Śrīpur, Havelī, Dharampur and eastern Mithila. It would be a mistake to dismiss this material as a mere repetition of the principal genealogical theory, for it preserves the memory of particular villages, temples, scholars, freedom fighters and local families.

Jahānpur and the Installation of an Image in 1708 CE

In the account of Jahānpur, the installation of an image in 1708 CE supplies a chronological marker for local religious history. Together with

names such as Puṇyānanda Jhā, Girānanda Ṭhākur and Rāsmohana Jhā, this event establishes a thread of cultural continuity for the village. If the original architectural evidence or an inscription survives, the pañjī and local tradition could corroborate one another.

Memories of the Independence Movement

References to families of freedom fighters in the villages of eastern Mithila connect modern political history with the social memory preserved by the pañjī. This material warrants comparison with official lists of freedom fighters, district gazetteers and oral history. The pañjī views events from the perspective of families; state archives view public positions and events. Reading both together produces a fuller account.

Viṣṇupur, Guṇānanda–Tīrthānanda and University Connections

The families associated with Viṣṇupur, Guṇānanda and Tīrthānanda, and genealogical references to a vice-chancellor of Mithila University reveal the regional social foundations of modern higher education. The history of a university is not merely the story of an institution's founding; long traditions of teaching within local scholarly families may form part of its background.

Nāśirā, Jyotirīśvara Ṭhākur and Other Scholarly Memories

A source claim connecting the Nāśirā/Naśirā region with the name of Jyotirīśvara Ṭhākur is of interest to literary historians. The historical identity of Jyotirīśvara, author of the Varṇaratnākara, is independently attested; a specific equivalence between his lineage and a pañjī entry, however, requires detailed examination of the original genealogical record, chronology and village references. This integrated essay retains the connection as a research lead, not as a proven line of descent.

Dharampur, Suragan Loām and Sarmast Alī Khān

In the local histories of Dharampur and Suragan Loām, names such as Sarmast Alī Khān, Rāghava Siṃha, scholars of Rasāṛh and the scholarly families of Dhamdāhā create a broader social picture of interactions across religious communities and political authority. If pañjī-centred studies of Mithila remain confined to Brahmin families alone, a substantial part of this shared regional history will be lost.

20. The Language of the Pañjī: Formula, Grammar and Onomastics

The pañjī is not written in continuous prose. Its principal strength lies in a compressed, formulaic grammar. Markers such as "so-and-so sut," "sutau," "sutā," "from such-and-such village such-and-such dau," "ddau," "aparā," "mūla," "pra." and "nī" indicate types of relationship in remarkably few

words. Learning to read the pañjī is therefore rather like learning to decode a modern system of abbreviations.

Sut, Sutau and Sutā

"Sut" may denote one son, "sutau" two sons or the dual number, while "sutā" may refer to a daughter or a particular context of offspring; usage can vary from manuscript to manuscript. When reading the original script, the distinction between grammatical number and scribal abbreviation must be checked. In automated text processing, reducing all three forms to a single category, "son," could corrupt relational data.

Dau/Ddau: Codes for Maternal Relationships

"Dau" is generally interpreted as an abbreviated indication of a dauhitra or maternal connection; "ddau" points to a doubled maternal reference or a cross-link at another level. Some reports translate these forms differently, as "maternal uncle–nephew" or "daughter's son." Rather than imposing a single English equivalent, a digital glossary should record context-dependent relationship types.

"Pra." and Double Names

"Pra." has been read as a commonly used name, a familiar nickname, or in some places as an abbreviation for "first." When several meanings are possible for the same abbreviation, a critical edition should preserve the original sign and supply an editorial note. Familiar names in Samaulī and Nagarām show that household names were practical instruments of personal identification.

Sanskrit, Maithili, Persian and English Influences

The older formulae are strongly Sanskritic, with titles such as rājā, upādhyāya, Mahāmahopādhyāya, jyotiṣī, vaiyākaraṇa and śāntivigrahika. Medieval and Mughal strata introduce Persianate administrative words such as Rāy, mansabdār, hazārī and Chaudharī. The colonial period brings terms for advocate, pleader, jury, university and degree; the modern period adds engineer, professor, physician, scientist and administrator. Loanwords within personal designations are living evidence of changing social institutions.

The History of Place Names

An older spelling of a village may differ from its modern revenue-record name: "Maṅgraunī" in one place and "Maṅgaurī" in another; "Sodarpur" and "Sodarpurā"; "Khauāl" and "Khauār"; "Darihar" and "Dariharā." Sound change, local pronunciation, scribal habits and transliteration into

Devanagari all contribute to these variations. For linguists, the pañjī is a long-term repository of place names.

Seven Types of Names

The Nagarāmī report broadly groups names into seven tendencies: deity-derived names; Sanskritic literary or philosophical names; Vaiṣṇava or Śaiva devotional names; Persian-influenced administrative names; folk or household names; compound names of the colonial and modern periods; and names accompanied by professions or titles. These are not rigid categories, but they provide a useful framework for studying the long-term transformation of thousands of names.

21. The Pañjī as an Institution of Social Memory, Power and Knowledge

A genealogy does not merely answer the question, "Who was whose father?" It makes social decisions about whose memory will be publicly preserved, whose name will be recorded alongside a prestigious title, whose relationship will be entered as a "dūṣaṇa," and whose line will remain incomplete. In this sense, the pañjī is an instrument of both memory and power.

Pañjīkārs as "Professionals of Memory"

The expertise of the pañjīkār arose at the intersection of written registers, oral tradition and social attestation. A family might remember seven or ten generations of its ancestors; without professional custodians of memory, however, it would have been difficult to retain the interlocking marriage connections of hundreds of villages, their pravaras, mūlas, dūṣaṇas and references to collateral branches. The pañjīkār thus became a specialist in the social memory of the community.

Written Memory Does Not Supplant Oral Tradition

The pañjī's abbreviated formulae themselves show that the written text is not self-sufficient. The pañjīkār orally explained the significance of abbreviations, village bynames, references to collateral branches and page citations. Written and oral transmission should therefore be seen not as adversaries but as interdependent practices. The greatest risk of digital conversion is that this body of oral interpretation may disappear.

An Instrument of Social Stratification

The categories Śrotriya, Yogya, Pañjībaddha, Vaṃśadhara and Jayavāra; higher and intermediate mūlas; collateral-branch registers; and marriage certifications could all confer formal recognition on social prestige. Where genealogical scrutiny determined eligibility for marriage, the register became a gatekeeper to social life. This structure may be examined

through Louis Dumont's analysis of caste hierarchy, Max Weber's status groups, Pierre Bourdieu's cultural and social capital, or Michel Foucault's relationship between knowledge and power. Theories, however, must not be imposed upon the source.

The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī as "Counter-Memory"

The principal pañjī records the accepted succession of prestigious lineages; the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī records violations of rules, prohibited relationships, marginalised castes and communities, widows, devadāsīs, unknown maternal lines and social disputes. In this sense, the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī is a shadow archive of the principal register's memory. A detail omitted from a prestigious family genealogy might survive in the register of "transgressions."

The Loss of Knowledge: The "Tegachhiyā Problem"

For certain branches, the pañjī itself acknowledges the loss of information. This recognition of its own limits complicates the archive's reliability: it makes no claim to omniscience, but preserves formulaic information insofar as that information is known. A modern database should likewise recognise "unknown" as a legitimate data value. Inserting conjectural names to fill gaps would be a violation of archival integrity.

22. Comparative Genealogy: A Dialogue with Other Traditions of the World

The source reports compare the pañjī with Chinese zupu clan genealogies, Jewish yichus, European heraldry and royal genealogies, Māori whakapapa, Rajput lineage registers and modern religious genealogical collections. Such comparison is productive only when it accounts for differences as well as similarities.

Chinese clan genealogies are often revised at fixed intervals by patrilineal descent groups; the pañjī was more closely associated with professional genealogists and an institutional system of marriage verification. Jewish yichus concerns religious status and marriage eligibility, but does not necessarily require the elaborate local cross-referencing of village, mūla and dau found in the pañjī. European heraldic and aristocratic genealogies primarily concern the nobility, whereas Mithila's pañjī encompasses an extensive network of families within a particular religious and professional community. The Rajput traditions of the Cāraṇs and Bhāṭs furnish some of the closest South Asian comparisons, although their structures of written cross-reference differ.

What Distinguishes the Pañjī

The distinctive character of the pañjī does not lie in exaggerated claims that it is the "oldest" or "most scientific" system. Its demonstrable characteristics are long-term, multigenerational records; professional genealogists; a direct social role in premarital verification; multidimensional identities based on gotra, pravara, mūla and maternal village; a separate register of dūṣaṇa; village-based cross-referencing; and evidence of continued updating into modern times. The comparative study of this particular combination is genuinely important.

A Methodological Resemblance to Navya-Nyāya

Some sources identify a cultural resemblance between the formulaic character of the pañjī and the analytical language of Navya-Nyāya. No direct historical causal relationship has been established. Nonetheless, in Mithila's intellectual environment, both traditions display an inclination towards fine classification, technical terms for relationships, exceptions, evidence and adjudication. The ideal that a pañjīkār's decision should rest on the actual register, prior attestation and the matching of relationships invites comparison with philosophical reflection on pramāṇa, or valid evidence.

23. The Pañjī and Its Modern Crisis: From Living Institution to Endangered Archive

In the twenty-first century, the pañjī faces two contrary developments. Digital images, search technologies, Devanagari transliteration and public access have become more feasible than ever before. Yet the traditional profession of the pañjīkār, the ability to read Mithilākṣara, the physical condition of the volumes and the practical use of genealogical verification in marriage are weakening. Technological preservation is advancing even as the social uses of the institution are changing.

The Declining Use of Pañjī Verification in Marriage

One modern report estimates that approximately one-fifth of marriages take place without consulting the pañjī. No independent regional survey substantiates this percentage; it must therefore be treated solely as a source estimate. Nevertheless, the broader trend is credible: education, urbanisation, inter-caste and interreligious marriages, love marriages, migration and matrimonial websites have diminished the pañjīkār's formerly indispensable role.

The Economic Insecurity of Pañjīkārs

If a family uses a pañjīkār's services only a few times a year, it becomes difficult to sustain the expertise as a full-time profession. Younger

generations seek other occupations. The ability to read the registers may then vanish with elderly pañjīkārs as a form of embodied personal capital. Preservation means more than scanning: it also requires recording specialists as they read aloud, pronounce names, explain abbreviations, identify villages and recount the oral histories of disputed branches.

Physical Deterioration

Humidity, termites, insects, acidic paper, excessive exposure to sunlight, water, oil, dust and repeated handling damage the volumes. Older local methods of preservation deserve respect; nevertheless, present-day collections require controlled archival temperature and humidity, acid-free enclosures, pest management, high-resolution imaging and disaster backups. The original volumes must remain protected even after digitisation. A digital copy is not a substitute for the original but a surrogate for consultation.

Privacy and Ethics

Modern pañjīs contain information about living persons, marriages, inter-caste relationships, so-called "transgressions," occupations and possibly personal disputes. Releasing all such data without restriction on the open internet would raise ethical concerns. Public historical documents and sensitive family details concerning living individuals require different access policies. Caste-based derogatory labels in the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī may be retained for critical analysis of the original source, but it would be inappropriate to reuse them to stigmatise living people.

24. Digital Reconstruction: Making the Pañjī Searchable Without Losing Its Meaning

Photographs of pages alone are insufficient for digitising the pañjī. A satisfactory digital edition requires five layers: the original image, diplomatic transliteration, normalised text, relational data and editorial annotation. The layers should be linked to one another, but the original text must never be overwritten.

24.1 The Original Image

Every page should be preserved as a high-resolution colour image, with a scale and colour reference, in the original volume-and-page sequence. Filenames should be based on permanent identification numbers. If a page is scanned again, the earlier image should not be deleted; its version history should be retained.

24.2 Transliteration

Transliteration from Mithilākṣara into Devanagari should remain faithful to the letters of the original. Uncertain characters, erased passages, marginalia, abbreviations, corrections and rewritten text should be recorded with distinct marks. Conjectural readings must not be presented as certain.

24.3 Normalisation

Standard forms may be added to make village names, personal names, titles and dates searchable, but the original spellings must be retained alongside them. For example, the standard modern identification of "Maṅgraunī/Maṅgaurī" should occupy one field and the original reading another. The same applies to "Khauāl/Khauār," "Sodarpur/Sodarpurā" and similar variants.

24.4 Relational Data

Every person should have a persistent identifier. Father; mother, if known; sons and daughters; spouse or spouses; maternal kin; gotra; pravara; mūla; original village; village of residence; occupation; titles; source page; branch code; and date of marriage should all occupy separate fields. The relationship type expressed by "dau/ddau" must remain linked to the original wording. Where its meaning is disputed, "uncertain" should be an admissible value.

24.5 Levels of Evidence

Every conclusion may be assigned an evidentiary category: directly attested in the original manuscript; present in a later copy; found in a printed edition; explained orally by a pañjīkār; conjectured in a modern report; or independently confirmed by an external historical source. Without this distinction, a digital database would create the misleading impression that all recorded statements possess equal factual standing.

Maps of Relationships and Places

A digital pañjī should be a network, not merely a family tree. One person may be connected through multiple marriages, maternal relationships, bynames, migrations and branch references. A network visualisation should therefore accompany the genealogical tree. Linking historical village names to modern coordinates could make it possible to map marriages and migrations across time. Where a geographic identification is conjectural, its uncertainty must be stated clearly.

The Limits of Machine Reading

Automated character recognition may still produce errors when applied to Mithilākṣara manuscripts. Abbreviations, old handwriting, stains, broken characters, conjunct letters and village names are especially vulnerable to misreading. The machine should be an assistant, not the final editor. Every significant relationship should be published only after human verification.

Digital principle: the original image is the basis for verification; transliteration is a bridge to the reader; normalisation is an aid to searching; relational data supply the structure for analysis; and annotation is an honest record of uncertainty.

25. Critical Limits of the Pañjī as Historical Evidence

The pañjī is extraordinarily valuable, but value is not the same as infallibility. Enthusiastic claims in the sources must be distinguished from the evidentiary standing of the archive itself.

450–2009 CE: Caution Concerning the Word "Continuous"

The project title describes genealogical memory extending from 450 to 2009 CE. Some reports seek to trace lineages back to the fifth through ninth centuries through Āryabhaṭa, ancient scholars or early royal dynasties. Yet surviving copies, written volumes and modern editions may belong to considerably later periods. "450–2009" should be understood as the chronological scope claimed by the project; it would not yet be justified to regard it as proof of uninterrupted, contemporary documentation for every year or every generation.

1326 CE and the Chronology of Harisiṃhadeva

Several sources give Śaka 1248, equivalent to 1326 CE, as the date of institutionalisation. Other historical chronologies place the end of Harisiṃhadeva's rule at approximately 1324 CE. The discrepancy may concern the reading of the Śaka date, its conversion to the Common Era, the date of a royal order, a later tradition or the identification of a particular person. The consolidated study marks this inconsistency as it stands, without declaring one version "correct" in the absence of an original dated document.

The Number of Gotras

The complete traditional list gives twenty gotras, whereas a count for one particular volume of the ancient pañjī identifies seventeen gotras in active use. This may be a difference in sample coverage. Some sources also give

different counts of mūlas within individual gotras, including Bharadvāja, Garga and Parāśara. It would be appropriate to establish definitive numbers only after preparing a comprehensive index of the original digital text.

167 Mūlas, of Which 34 or 35 Are Principal

The figures of 167 mūlas in all and thirty-four principal mūlas—or thirty-five when the Khānāma branch of Phanandaha is included—recur in the sources. But the historical criteria, periods, regions and politics of classification that determined what counted as "principal" require critical investigation. Social prestige must not be represented as natural or biological superiority.

Five/Seven versus Five/Six

The distinction between the dharmaśāstric rules of sapiṇḍa kinship and the practical modifications applied by pañjīkārs has been discussed above. One report gives different limits for Śrotriya and Pañjībaddha groups; another gives identical dharmaśāstric limits for everyone. Encoding a single, eternal rule in a digital rule engine would erase historical variation. Different versions of a rule, their periods and the groups to which they applied need distinct metadata.

Claims Concerning Genomes and Chromosomes

Some reports present precise figures resembling modern genetic claims: percentages of "shared DNA," Y-chromosomal exogamy, or the purported disappearance of harmful alleles by the fifth or seventh generation. Without scientific testing in contemporary population genetics, such claims cannot be accepted. The pañjī's marriage-distance rules certainly constitute a social means of avoiding close kinship; to equate them point for point with particular molecular-genetic thresholds would be an exaggeration.

The Coincidence of Famous Names

Names such as "Vidyāpati," "Gaṅgeśa," "Gaṅgānātha," "Jyotirīśvara" and "Āryabhaṭa" resemble those of celebrated historical figures. The repetition of names within genealogies is common. Identification requires agreement among the father's name, mūla, village, generation, period and title, together with external corroboration. A name match alone is not evidence.

The Bias of Sources Organised by Social Category

The pañjī was principally an institution of particular caste and lineage groups; it cannot by itself supply a demographic history of all Mithila. The

Dūṣaṇa Pañjī preserves the names of some marginalised groups, but the perspective of the main genealogies is predominantly that of upper-caste men. A comprehensive social history of Mithila must also draw on farmers, Dalits, Adivasis, Muslims, women, artisans, merchants and other castes and communities, together with state records, folk literature, inscriptions, land documents and oral histories.

26. The Pañjī as a Literary Form: Brief Sentences, a Vast World

At first, it may seem strange to call the pañjī literature. There is no plot, no developed characterisation and no descriptive scene. Yet when thousands of compressed statements are read together, they create an immense collective narrative of time, marriage, migration, royal power, knowledge, prestige, decline, reintegration, nicknames, occupations and memory.

The Poetics of the Formula

"So-and-so's son," "dau from such-and-such a family," "aparā," "pra.," "grāmārambha": the language is remarkably spare. Its principle of "few syllables, many meanings" obliges the reader to fill the gaps. One woman has no recorded name, only the name of her village; a king receives an exceptionally long title; a scholar's name is followed by "Ayācī"; a branch is marked "extinct." The unequal distribution of detail discloses the society's hierarchy of values.

The Stories in Bynames

"Sarvajña Garīb," "Āṅkhī," "Naharā," "Vāgīśa" and "Ayācī": such names are miniature narratives in themselves. When formal genealogy makes room for names used in ordinary life, the austerity of the archive acquires a human dimension. A household name, scholarly honorific, royal distinction or occupational title may constitute an entire line of a person's social "character."

The Editing of Time

A copyist's date of 1856, a marriage in 2003, an edition dated 2008 and ancient royal dynasties coexist in the pañjī. From a literary standpoint, it is a multitemporal text: new lives continued to be inscribed on old pages. To erase this coexistence of times in a modern edition and manufacture a "clean chronology" would distort the nature of the source.

"Śabdaśāstram" and Fiction Drawn from the Pañjī

The Maithili story "Śabdaśāstram," based on the genealogical controversy surrounding Gaṅgeśa, demonstrates how archives can inspire modern imaginative literature. Archival fact and fiction are distinct genres.

Literature may use imagination to explore historical gaps, but research writing must preserve a clear boundary between invention and evidence.

27. Consolidated Conclusion: The Pañjī as a Living Culture of Social Data

The importance of Mithila's pañjī system lies not simply in its antiquity but, more fundamentally, in its structure. Gotra, pravara, mūla, ancestral village, bījī puruṣa, uṭeṛha, maternal village, dau/ddau, branches, dūṣaṇa, marriage colophons, occupational titles and village codes together form a multilayered social memory.

This memory regulated marriage and constituted social ranks. It preserved relationships between royal authority and scholarly families, registered migrations and changes in names and language, saved some marginal relationships from oblivion—even when it marked them as "dūṣaṇa"—and traced the transformation of families into the modern worlds of universities and bureaucracy.

Critical examination of the pañjī is equally essential. Caste hierarchies, the absence of women's personal names, the stigmatising language of "dūṣaṇa," possible interventions of wealth and status, exaggerated identifications with famous names, the scientific limitations of genomic metaphors, conflicting dates and incomplete branches are all elements of its study, not obstacles to it. Critical reading does not diminish the pañjī; it makes it more reliable as a historical source.

In the digital age, the most useful prospect is a resource that brings together images of the original Mithilākṣara manuscripts, Devanagari transliterations, normalised village and personal names, a relational database, the oral knowledge of pañjīkārs, privacy policies and critical annotations. Such a project would help people trace ancestry, but it could also establish a long-term foundation for the social history, linguistics, onomastics, migration studies, political history, intellectual traditions, women's studies and digital humanities of Mithila.

Final principle: the pañjī should be regarded neither as an infallible science nor merely as a caste-bound relic. It is a historical social technology in which memory, rules, power, family, geography and knowledge have been inscribed alongside one another for centuries.

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Source Audit and Consolidation Report

Audit Method

All twenty Word files in the ZIP archive were extracted separately and their texts examined, including paragraphs and table cells. The initial source collection contained approximately 125,814 words (with some variation according to the method of word segmentation). The same theories, lists of gotras, marriage rules, types of pañjī, historical narratives and digital projects recurred across the separate reports. In consolidation, equivalent repetitions were retained only once, but every file's distinctive facts, examples, controversies, places, persons, volumes, blocks and points of criticism were integrated under the appropriate themes.

The original files contained a total of 548 superscript runs, primarily reference numbers in the question-and-answer material and in Reports 01–03. The consolidated essay was prepared as a new document; consequently, the superscripts were removed and book references placed in standard form in the bibliography. Unrelated statements about the work process, concluding formulae and editorial instructions unconnected with the article's subject, found in the original reports, were not retained in the final article.

Coverage List for the Twenty Source Files

No.	Source File	Approx. Source Words	Principal Locations in Consolidated Essay	Coverage Note
1	0 — Initial Discussion of the Pañjī	3,188	§§2–10, 23–25	Original history of the pañjī, marriage rules, social categories and digital questions; distinctive facts retained and repetitions removed.
2	00 — Dūṣaṇa Pañjī	6,074	§§9–11	Ninety-seven dūṣaṇa tables, the Gaṅgeśa episode, women and the margins, readmission; process-related statements removed.
3	01 — Study of the Genealogical Theory of the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī	4,167	§§3–10, 21–25	Seven pañjīs, thirty-two ancestors, gotra and pravara, comparative theory, the dūṣaṇa counter-archive and epistemology.
4	02 — Research Report on the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī	4,527	§§9–11, 21–22; Bibliography	Anthropology, caste mobility, Gaṅgeśa's lineage, memory and stigma, and primary and secondary references.
5	1.0 — Study of Pañjī Genealogical Theory	4,681	§§2–8, 21–25	Theory of descent, mūla and bījī puruṣa, uṭeṛha, professional pañjīkārs, social stratification and modern crises.
6	1.1.1 — Research Report on Prācīna Pañjī, Volume I	4,008	§12	Pages 1–65: Halāyudha, scholarly sequences, 122 villages, maternal-line cycles and the 1856 colophon.

No.	Source File	Approx. Source Words	Principal Locations in Consolidated Essay	Coverage Note
7	1.1.2 — Research Report on Pañjī Volume I, Pages 66–347	4,977	§13	Karmahā, Rataulī–Dariharā, Avalamba–Sarasvatī, Mādhava Siṃha, Nepal and marriages in 2003–04.
8	1.1.3 — Research Report on Pañjī Volume II, Pages 348–690	4,601	§14	The Sodarpur centre, royal lineages, K.C.I.E., a marriage in Sweden, universities, poets and modernity.
9	1.2.1 — Classical Report on Genome and Pañjī-Prabandha	4,724	§§15, 21–25	Supplementary notes, social networks, patrilines and maternal ties, genomic metaphors and modern transformation.
10	1.2.2 — Report on the Genomic Discussion of Mithila's Pañjī	5,820	§§15, 19, 23–25	Loām–Sugaunā, Bhaur–Rājgrām, educated lineages, a date in 2008 and social critique; unrelated process statements removed.
11	1.3.1 — Analysis of the Nagarām Pañjī	5,831	§16	Blocks 1–225: household names, technicians, judges, IAS officers, members of parliament, occupations, migration and onomastics.
12	1.3.2 — Analytical Report on the Pañjikā-Nagarāmī	5,956	§17	Blocks 226–352: Samaulī, Balirājpur, Vāgīśa, lawyers, authors, daughters in IPS/IAS and jury service.
13	1.3.3 — Analysis of Pañjī-Prabandha	4,973	§18	Blocks 359–466: scholarly groups, dynasties, Oin/Simraungarh, names, occupations, geography and cross-references.
14	2.0 — Study of Pañjī Genealogical Theory	5,687	§§4–8, 20–25	Data layers, documentary evidence, demography, social law, computational genealogy and limitations.
15	2.1 — Research Report on Pañjī-Prabandha	4,242	§§21–25	Social memory, alliance theory, stratification, cross-references, global comparisons and the stakes of digitisation.
16	Question-and-Answer Collection	24,125	Throughout §§2–25	Distinctive rules from extensive questions and answers, twenty gotras, sixteen chhaṭṭhīs, social disputes, reform and modern interpretations; repetitions consolidated.
17	Report 01	4,089	§§1–8, 25	Mithila's geography, Pāla and Karṇāṭa backgrounds, the Harinātha/Lakhimā narrative, gotra–mūla tables and social categories.
18	Report 02	9,285	§§2–25	Extensive repetition of earlier reports, along with suppression/dūṣaṇa, theory and tables; unique details included and repetitions removed.
19	Report 03	3,784	§§19, 23–25	Purnia and eastern Mithila, Jahānpur in 1708, local scholars and memories of independence, the pañjīkār crisis

No.	Source File	Approx. Source Words	Principal Locations in Consolidated Essay	Coverage Note
				and preservation.
20	Report 2	11,075	§§3–8, 20–25	Pañjī theory in the form of a teaching guide: twenty gotras, 167 mūlas, marriage rules and initial sample tables; repetitions consolidated.

Thematic Cross-Check

Origins of the pañjī, collective written records (samūha-lekhya), institutionalisation and the Harinātha–Lakhimā narrative: incorporated.

Guṇākara Jhā, Śaṅkaradatta, Vijayadatta and the institution of the pañjīkār: incorporated.

The seven types of pañjī: incorporated.

Twenty gotras, pravaras, 167 mūlas, 34 or 35 principal mūlas and bījī puruṣas: incorporated.

Thirty-two ancestors, sixteen chhaṭṭhīs, the five/seven and five/six controversies, and the Kāṭhamāmā and related rules: incorporated.

Śrotriya/Yogya/Pañjībaddha/Vaṃśadhara/Jayavāra, branch registers, social demotion or advancement, bikauā and reform committees: incorporated.

Mithilākṣara, manuscript conservation, copying and digital editions: incorporated.

Ninety-seven tables in the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī; references to a leatherworker woman, Yavana, devadāsī, widow, the guru's wife, a woman described as fallen by the roadside, unknown lineage and readmission: incorporated.

The controversy concerning Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and allegations of the suppression of scholarship: incorporated as source claims.

Women's structural presence and absence of personal names, particular women's names, and daughters in modern professions: incorporated.

Prācīna Pañjī, Volume I, pages 1–65: principal villages, Halāyudha, scholars, offices, maternal-line cycles and colophons: incorporated.

Pages 66–347: Karmahā, Rataulī–Dariharā, Avalamba–Sarasvatī, Mādhava Siṃha, mansabdārs, Nepal and marriages in 2003–04: incorporated.

Pages 348–690: Sodarpur, royal lineages, colonial honours, a marriage in Sweden or an inter-caste marriage, universities, poets and occupations: incorporated.

Genome and supplementary-note volumes: Loām–Sugaunā, Bhaur–Rājgrām, Khaṇḍbalā, Nyāya scholars and a date in 2008: incorporated.

Nagarām 1–225: Sandahpur, Khāṅguṛ, Kanhaulī, Raiyām, Rohaṛ, occupations, names and migration: incorporated.

Nagarāmī 226–352: Samaulī, Balirājpur, modern academic degrees, lawyers, writers, daughters serving in the IPS or IAS, and women's achievements: incorporated.

Nagarām 359–466: Vicāṛhī, Parahaṭ, Maṅgaurī, Pilakhavāṛ, Baiganī, the Oin royal dynasty, Nahas, Chānpurā and outlying villages: incorporated.

Purnia and eastern Mithila, local temples, scholars and memories of the freedom struggle: incorporated.

Formulaic pañjī language, dual names, occupational honorifics, onomastics and place names: incorporated.

Social memory, power, comparative genealogy and Navya-Nyāya epistemology: incorporated.

Modern crisis, physical preservation, economic insecurity, privacy and the digital data model: incorporated.

Conflicts among sources and dates, numbers of gotras and mūlas, genomic claims, identification of famous figures and source biases: explicitly incorporated into the critical examination.

9. "Kusmā-Salhes": Folk Epic, Resistance and the Dramaturgy of Love

Abstract

This study of the title play "Kusmā-Salhes" centres on Salhes-Nāch, the folk epic, the cultural memory of marginalised communities, the heroine Kusmā's self-determination, political resistance, the plurality of rasas, and the wider human significance of love. Its comparative criticism considers the play's folk sources, epic scale, subaltern consciousness and theatrical imagery in relation to one another.

Keywords: Kusmā-Salhes; Salhes-Nāch; folk epic; resistance; subaltern; love; folk memory

1. Introduction, Narrative Structure and Historical-Cultural Context

Kunal's third and most extensive play, "Kusmā-Salhes," occupies the central place in the collection. At approximately seventy pages, it is the collection's focal point artistically, ideologically and culturally. It is based on the epic of "Rājā Salhes," the folk-deity and hero of Mithila's Dusadh community, and on the tradition of folk theatre derived from that epic, "Salhes-Nāch."

The narrative encompasses a vast geography: Mahisauthā, Morang, Bāghgaṛh, Revā-Dāh, Bhot/Tibet, Samadāgaṛh, Pakaṛiyā, Gaṛh-Tareganā and Rangīlāgaṛh. These place names create a geopolitical world extending across India, Nepal and Tibet. The dramatis personae are equally epic in scale: the hero Salhes, the heroine Kusmā (a woman of the Mālin community), Hīrāman (the parrot-narrator), Vipṭā (the clown), Ṭhankā (a tiger), Bankā (a bear), Kunṭā (a forest-dweller), the goddess Durgā, and numerous kings, armies and enemies.

The play has five principal dramatic movements: (1) the preliminary performance, comprising a syncretic invocation (sumiran) and a metatheatrical introduction by Vipṭā and Hīrāman; (2) the introduction of Kusmā and her discipline of inner purification; (3) Salhes's valour, the first meeting and Durgā's blessing; (4) the invasion from Bhot, conspiracy and imprisonment; and (5) the proclamation of an independent consciousness, victory through popular solidarity, and the concluding declaration of the principle of love.

2. Indian Theories of Drama

2.1 Salhes-Nāch: The Independent Aesthetics of Folk Theatre

Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra formulates a theory of drama from within the Sanskrit tradition. Mithila's "Salhes-Nāch," however, is an autonomous

folk-theatrical tradition with its own performance grammar. Its constituent elements include the collective singing of the samājī (serving as a chorus); the sumiran, a folk-theatrical auspicious invocation that calls upon Hindu, Muslim and tribal deities together; Vipṭā's function as clown; Hīrāman the parrot's role as narrator; and acclamations before Salhes enters. These are the folk theatre's own dramatic conventions and ritual-performance elements.

Kunal adopts this entire folk grammar with authenticity: purification, sequence, song and forms of address all remain consonant with the folk tradition. In this sense, the play is not an elite theatre's imitation of folk drama but a literary re-presentation of folk theatre. It is essential to recognise the distinction.

2.2 A Festival of Rasa: A Multicoloured Affective Structure

According to the Sanskrit poetics tradition, an accomplished dramatic work should possess one dominant rasa, in whose service the other rasas function as auxiliaries. The complexity of "Kusmā-Salhes" lies in its having not a single dominant rasa but a veritable festival of rasas.

Śṛṅgāra (the love of Kusmā and Salhes, a folk counterpart of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa: "He is Kisan Gosāin, and you are Rādhārānī"); vīra (Salhes's martial prowess and compassion for a defeated enemy: "It is improper to pursue an army that has been defeated and is fleeing"); adbhuta (the extraordinary presence of Ṭhankā, Bankā and Hīrāman, and the manifestation of Durgā); karuṇa (an impossible love—Salhes is married, Kusmā is a Mālin woman, and caste boundaries obstruct their union); bhakti (worship of Durgā and the reconciliation of all religions in the sumiran); and bībhatsa/bhayānaka (Sūchong's conspiracy and the cruelties of imprisonment).

Bharata admits a synthesis of rasas in which aṅgī-rasa (the dominant rasa) and aṅga-rasa (the subsidiary rasa) produce a complex aesthetic experience. In this play, śṛṅgāra and vīra become, in turn, the dominant rasa, while Durgā's declaration brings the two into complementary relation: "Having joined with Kusmā, now move among the hearts of the people; devote your life solely to their happiness." Love (śṛṅgāra) itself thus becomes the source of inspiration for heroic duty.

2.3 Subaltern Aesthetics: A Challenge to the Canon

The hero of Sanskrit dramatic theory generally comes from a royal-sage or divine lineage. The Dusadh hero finds no place in that tradition. Kunal's most daring dramatic decision is to place the epic of a subaltern community—one subordinated within the social hierarchy—at the centre of an "epic drama."

Within Maithili poetic tradition, on one side stands the Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa love-poetry tradition of the pre-Jyotirīśvara lyricist Vidyāpati; on the other is the courtly and literary tradition of Vidyāpati Ṭhakkur, the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭa writer of the Śivasiṃha era. It would not be appropriate to treat these two as a single person or as a single line of sources. Kunal chooses a different path: Kusmā as "Radhiyā," a folk form of Rādhā, and Salhes as "Kisan Gosāin," a folk form of Kṛṣṇa. This symbolic substitution is a dramatic declaration that the love story of the Dusadh folk tradition is equivalent to the Maithili literary mainstream—and indeed lies at its roots.

2.4 Kusmā's Inner Purification: An Indigenous Yogic Discipline

The dialogue between Hīrāman and Kusmā in the second scene contains a remarkable sequence of inner purification: a folk transformation of yogic discipline. "Sweep out your home … sweep away envy, pride, hatred, greed and attachment … I plastered it with the water of compassion … I made it fragrant with the sandalwood of affection." This is not a physical exercise but an emotional journey towards inward purification. In the Indian philosophical tradition, particularly in the traditions of bhakti, "purification of the heart" (citta-viśuddhi) is understood as a precondition for the attainment of love.

Kunal presents this philosophy of devotion against a humorous background. Hīrāman first demands a reward—gold, a diamond necklace, a silver bowl—and only then offers guidance. The playfulness of folk expression makes the philosophy of devotion not "simplistic" but "alive."

3. Western Theories of Drama

3.1 Gramsci: Subaltern History and the Organic Intellectual

In his Prison Notebooks, the Italian Marxist thinker Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937) presented the history of subaltern—subordinated and deprived—groups as an alternative to dominant historiography. By an "organic intellectual," Gramsci meant a person who brings the cultural expression of their own community into a higher literary or intellectual sphere.

From this perspective, Kunal is an organic intellectual of Maithili theatre. He takes the Dusadh epic of Salhes, formerly kept alive within the restricted communal performance tradition of Salhes-Nāch, and brings it onto the modern stage of Vidyāpati Bhavan. This cultural translation is a political act in Gramsci's sense: a subaltern voice enters a mainstream cultural space.

From a Gramscian perspective, Salhes's prison speech is the most significant moment: "My life may be in your grasp, Emperor, but my

thoughts and feelings cannot be bound." This declaration is a folk-theatrical version of the strategy of resistance to "cultural hegemony" described by Gramsci.

3.2 Magical Realism: The Theatrical Presence of a Folk Worldview

The writer Gabriel García Márquez (1927–2014), described here as British–Colombian, and the Indian–British writer Salman Rushdie (born 1947) employed "magical realism" in their fiction: the wondrous or supernatural becomes a natural component of reality, without occasioning any special surprise or explanation.

In this play, Ṭhankā the tiger and Bankā the bear are Salhes's conversational companions; Hīrāman the parrot carries messages between heaven and the mortal world; and Durgā appears in person to bless the folk hero. These are natural elements of the Dusadh folk worldview, not "miracles." In the terms of magical-realist theory, it would be more exact to describe these elements not as "magical" but as "folk-cosmological real."

One important principle associated here with Rushdie is that magical realism becomes effective when the writer accepts that "magic" as real, rather than superimposing it as a decorative device from outside. Kunal's play possesses this authenticity: Ṭhankā, Bankā, Hīrāman and Durgā are indispensable to the story's structure, not ornaments.

3.3 Brecht: Lehrstück (the Teaching Play) and Popular Politics

In his theory of the Lehrstück, or teaching play, Brecht maintained that theatre can convey a clear political and ethical message. Through the samājī and through Hīrāman and Viṭṭā, this play offers numerous "moments of instruction": Salhes's "mantra for a life free from fear," and Durgā's command to "move among the hearts of the people and dedicate one's life to their welfare."

Kunal nevertheless differs from Brecht on an important point: Brecht sought distance from emotional identification, whereas Kunal regards love and public service as two sides of the same coin. The intellectual and political instruction of the Lehrstück is immersed here in the feeling of śṛṅgāra and the rasa of devotion. This is a kind of "emotional epic theatre" that extends beyond the Brechtian category.

3.4 Homi Bhabha: Cultural Identity and Resistance

In The Location of Culture, the Indian–British postcolonial thinker Homi Bhabha (born 1949) introduced concepts such as the "third space" and cultural hybridity, through which colonised groups appropriate colonial discourse and disrupt it from within.

Sūchong's conspiracy in this play—the plan to separate Salhes from Kusmā—is a colonial strategy. He knows that Kusmā's "affection and knowledge" are sources of Salhes's strength. Once Kusmā has been separated from him, Salhes will be weakened. This is the "erasure of cultural identity" discussed here in relation to Bhabha, a practice adopted by colonial rule. Salhes recognises the plan and declares that feelings and ideas cannot be imprisoned.

4. Chinese Theories of Drama

4.1 Yi: Righteous Conduct and Military Ethics

In the Chinese ethical and philosophical tradition, yi (righteousness or duty) is a central value. In the Confucian tradition it means fulfilling one's duty in the proper manner, even when doing so is difficult. Guan Yu (Guan Di), one of the best-known heroes of Chinese folk theatre and epic, was renowned for his conduct in accordance with yi; he showed respect even to defeated enemies.

Precisely such conduct in accordance with yi appears in Salhes: "It would be wrong to pursue an army that has been defeated and is fleeing." This is not merely diplomatic expediency, but a principle of ethical military conduct supported by both Indian kṣatriya-dharma and the Chinese tradition of yi. Like Guan Yu, Salhes also becomes a folk deity for his people—not on the battlefield, but in their hearts.

4.2 Hualian: Dramatic Character Types and Colour Symbolism

In classical Chinese theatre (jingju, or Beijing opera), the hualian, or "painted face," is a distinctive role type in which facial colours indicate a character's moral disposition: red signifies courage and loyalty (Guan Yu); blue or green, formidable strength; white, villainy or cunning; and black, power and justice.

This symbolic system can be mapped onto the cast of "Kusmā-Salhes": Salhes = red hualian (courage and loyalty); Sūchong = white hualian (deviousness and conspiracy); Chūhaṛmall = blue (military strength); Kusmā = "tān" (a female role, yet a powerful one, the "forest goddess"); Hīrāman and Vipṭā = "chou" (clowns); Durgā = "umen" (divine appearance, shénmíng). This classification reveals a universal dramatic logic in the arrangement of the play's characters.

4.3 Tianming: The Mandate of Heaven and the Hero's Duty

In the Chinese political and philosophical tradition, tianming, or the "Mandate of Heaven," is an important concept. A ruler who serves the welfare of the people possesses tianming; one who corrupts or harms them loses it.

Durgā's blessing in the play corresponds to tianming: the goddess commands Salhes "to dedicate his life solely to the happiness of the people." This heavenly command legitimises Salhes's power to rule. By contrast, Sūchong—expansionist, greedy and oppressive towards his subjects—lacks tianming. In Kunal's play, this ethical and political philosophy ultimately declares Salhes "victorious," not through armed force but through the moral power of the people.

4.4 Minjian: The Theatricalisation of Folk Heroes

Chinese theatre history has a long tradition of bringing folk heroes to the stage, represented by "Miao-zhi-ying-zhong-zhuan" (Temple Hero Legends), which has made folk deities the protagonists of drama. The relation of this play to Salhes-Nāch follows a similar trajectory: a folk deity first becomes a hero of folk theatre and subsequently of literary theatre.

In the Chinese tradition, this transition—from folk or temple performance to literary theatre—runs parallel to the journey from the popular legend of Guan Yu through Romance of the Three Kingdoms and then to dramatic adaptation. The comparable passage of the Salhes epic—Salhes-Nāch to "Kusmā-Salhes" (Kunal, 2006)—expresses a cultural life cycle.

5. Israeli Theories of Drama

5.1 Eli Rozik: Theatrical Iconicity and Animal Characters

Eli Rozik's theory of theatrical iconicity is subjected to an extraordinary test in this play: the iconic representation of animal characters. Ṭhankā (a tiger), Bankā (a bear) and Hīrāman (a parrot) are represented on stage by actors' bodies. According to Rozik's theory, these characters are "icons": what they depict is a fictional animal existence, rather than a representation of the actor's own body.

More importantly, Rozik maintained that theatre can cross the boundary between human and animal because the icon is free from the limits of literal reality. The presence of Ṭhankā, Bankā and Hīrāman constitutes an "animistic iconography" of the Dusadh folk worldview, in which humans, animals and spirits possess equal standing within the same dramatic universe. This is "transgressive iconicity": iconicity that crosses boundaries.

5.2 A Parallel with Mizrahi Theatre: Reviving a Culturally Marginalised Tradition

In Israeli theatre, the "Mizrahi" cultural tradition, associated with Jews of Middle Eastern and North African origin, was long marginalised by dominant "Ashkenazi" cultural norms associated with European Jews. The Mizrahi theatre movement (from the 1970s to the present) is a movement

to bring this marginalised heritage—including Sephardi music, piyyutim and zemirot—into the mainstream.

In its Maithili setting, Kunal's "Kusmā-Salhes" may be regarded as a comparable movement. The Dusadh folk tradition of Salhes-Nāch has been marginal to Maithili's cultural hierarchy, in which Vidyāpati, Chandā Jhā and the elite poetic tradition have held sway. By taking this marginalised tradition to Vidyāpati Bhavan, an important institutional centre of Maithili culture, Kunal makes a cultural and political claim.

5.3 Hannah Arendt: Natality and Public Action

In The Human Condition, the German–American political philosopher Hannah Arendt (1906–1975) introduced the concept of "natality": every political action is a new beginning, a kind of "birth." Such an action becomes immortal in the public realm because it has witnesses.

Salhes's prison declaration—"Salhes may not remain, but a people filled with the mantra of a fearless life will remain"—is a "political action" in Arendt's sense. The declaration is made in Sūchong's prison, before Sūchong himself as witness; through that witnessing it becomes "immortal," a dramatic moment of "natality." Through this scene, Kunal transforms Salhes from a folk deity into a "political actor."

5.4 Shimon Levy: The Syncretic Sumiran and "Sacred Theatre"

In his theory of the "Theatre of the Sacred," Shimon Levy argued that, when communal religious values are re-presented on stage, theatre becomes a secular transformation of religious ritual.

The sumiran of the play's preliminary performance presents a particular test of Shimon Levy's theory. It is not merely a Hindu religious invocation: it also includes the Muslim pīr "Mīrā-Sultān," a deity of the western direction. "Parinām, namaste, ādāb, good evening, salām"—these greetings to the audience cross, in a single breath, the boundaries of religion, language, class and nation-state. From Levy's perspective, this is a theatre of the "radical sacred," rejecting divisive identities and imagining an inclusive community.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis

As the title play of the collection, "Kusmā-Salhes" is both its most fertile and its most challenging work for critical examination through the four theatrical traditions. Its many dimensions cannot be encompassed by any single critical perspective.

The Indian perspective: the autonomous folk-theatrical grammar of Salhes-Nāch; a festival of rasas (śṛṅgāra + vīra + bhakti + adbhuta); the

dramatic manifestation of subaltern aesthetics; and Durgā's blessing as a declaration of the inseparability of love, knowledge and public service.

The Western perspective: Gramsci's organic intellectual; an authentic folk version of magical realism; Brechtian "emotional epic theatre"; and Bhabha's account of cultural identity and resistance.

The Chinese perspective: Guan Yu-like ethics of yi; hualian character classification; tianming as the heavenly mandate represented by Durgā; and the minjian tradition of dramatising folk heroes.

The Israeli perspective: Rozik's transgressive animistic iconicity; the cultural parallel with Mizrahi theatre; Arendt's natality (the prison declaration as a political birth); and Levy's radically sacred sumiran.

The shared conclusion of all four traditions is that the play performs an act of "cultural justice." It brings the Dusadh hero Salhes to the centre of the Maithili literary stage, makes folk theatre the basis of literary drama, and declares love and service to the people to be indivisible. These three accomplishments together establish the play, by the criteria of Indian, Western, Chinese and Israeli theatrical thought, as both "excellent" and "necessary."

The final refrain that completes the play—"Love is truth, love is fragrance, the feeling of love is eternal; as a flower is without nectar, so what is life without love?"—reaches back through all these interpretations. The words constitute a declaration of the spirit of the entire collection.

Supplementary Analysis of the Social and Folk Narrative

The play "Kusmā-Salhes" is based on the story of Rājā Salhes, one of the most cherished folk heroes in Mithila's Dalit consciousness, especially among the Dusadh and Paswan communities. Kunal connects the folk elements of traditional Salhes-Nāch with the ideological discourse of modern theatre.

In Mithila, Salhes is established not merely as a valiant warrior but as a defender of disadvantaged groups against feudal oppression. When feudal kings and upper-class elements abducted and raped Dalit brides, Salhes formed his forest army, drawing on forest-dwelling communities, and brought that practice to an end. In the play, Anang Kusmā (Daunā Mālin), a nun of the Mahāyāna branch of Buddhism, appears as Salhes's beloved and intellectual companion. Her portrayal offers a remarkable dramatic example of social harmony and love across caste boundaries.

Salhes and Kusmā together destroy the deceitful tantric Chakranāth, who, in the name of superstition, practised the "Nāgadāsī" custom, causing two virgin girls to be killed each year by making them suckle venomous

snakes. The play is an epic narrative of Dalit identity, scientific consciousness and a folk hero's social resistance.

10. “Akhiyāsal”: Indian Poetics, Western Literary Theory and the Parallel-History Perspective

Abstract

“Akhiyāsal”: An Extended Critical Appreciation through Indian Poetics, Western Literary Theory and the Videha Parallel-History Perspective. Introduction: The Work, Its Author and the Point of Departure for Criticism. Dr Ramanand Jha ‘Raman’’s Akhiyāsal is a collection of critical essays reassessing the history of Maithili literature, the development of fiction, early novels, forgotten literary workers, national consciousness, lyric poetry, journalism, column-writing and the social concerns of modern fiction.

Keywords: Akhiyāsal · Indian · poetics · Western · theory · parallel · history

Abstract

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 The collection was published by the Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore, in 1995 and contains twenty-five independent critical essays. They originally appeared in periodicals such as Mithilā Mihir, Mithilāmod, Bhākhā, Maithilī Academy Patrikā, Basāt, Hālchāl and Maithilī Prakāś, and in the souvenir of the All India Maithili Sahitya Sammelan.

“Akhiyāsal”: An Extended Critical Appreciation through Indian Poetics, Western Literary Theory and the Videha Parallel-History Perspective

— Gajendra Thakur

Introduction: The Work, Its Author and the Point of Departure for Criticism

Dr Ramanand Jha ‘Raman’’s Akhiyāsal is a collection of critical essays reassessing the history of Maithili literature, the development of fiction, early novels, forgotten literary workers, national consciousness, lyric poetry, journalism, column-writing and the social concerns of modern fiction. The collection was published by the Central Institute of Indian

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The book begins by attempting to establish Pandit Shrikrishna Thakur and Chandraprabhā within the traditions of early Maithili fiction and the short-story collection, and ends with the contemporary fiction writer Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary. Thus its twenty-five essays encompass roughly two centuries, from the earliest Maithili storyteller to a contemporary practitioner. This breadth makes Akhiyāsal not merely a work of criticism but a foundation stone for a kind of parallel literary history. It is also the source both of the work's greatest originality and of its most serious limitations.

The book does not simply eulogise the established great men of literature. Its fundamental questions are these: who has been made memorable in the history of Maithili literature and who forgotten? Which work has been called the 'first'? Which manuscript never reached readers? What roles have institutions, journals, editors, publishers, centres of migration and social power played in the formation of literary recognition? The book's central purpose is unmistakable: to bring to light the early and neglected writers of Maithili prose and verse whom mainstream literary history has forgotten or for whom source material has remained 'unavailable'.

Rather than tracing a single linear history, Akhiyāsal's twenty-five chapters open up several parallel currents:

the search for early Maithili stories and novels;

the restoration to recognition of forgotten writers;

the freedom struggle and the awakening of consciousness about the mother tongue;

genre-based examination of fiction, song, humorous prose, columns and journalism;

the experiences of women, the poor, farmers, unemployed young people and oppressed groups;

the political ironies of the post-Independence period;

social transition, existential crisis and moral decline.

In this sense Akhiyāsal is not merely criticism; it is an important undertaking in the archival recovery of Maithili literature and the writing of a parallel history.

The present evaluation employs three critical paradigms together: (a) Indian poetics—rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, aucitya, rīti, alaṅkāra, sādhāraṇīkaraṇa and lokamaṅgala; (b) Western literary theory—historicism and New Historicism, Marxist sociological criticism, Formalism, feminist criticism, postcolonial criticism, existentialist and psychoanalytic perspectives, reader-response theory, the deconstructionist retrieval of marginal voices and the politics of the canon; and (c) the parallel-history paradigm of the Videha Parallel Literary Movement, together with the epistemology of Navya-Nyāya originating in Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. The third paradigm declares the restoration of endangered, marginalised and undocumented writers to be its aim, in opposition to mainstream canon formation; it uses the Navya-Nyāya concepts of hetvābhāsa, fallacious reasoning, and śabda-pramāṇa, verbal testimony, to expose ideological deception embedded in literature. From this third standpoint Akhiyāsal is a pioneering precursor, a proto-text: the work Ramanand Jha undertook through individual labour in the 1970s and 1980s receives an institutional, archival and democratic extension in the Videha movement.

This review is organised in two parts. The first examines the distinctive qualities, achievements and theoretical significance of each chapter; the second is devoted entirely to limitations, weaknesses and methodological difficulties.

Critical Paradigms

The Perspective of Indian Literary Theory

Rasa — The book's chapters examine karuṇa (pathos), vīra (heroism), hāsya (humour), śṛṅgāra (love), bhakti (devotion) and raudra (fury). Hunger and the disintegration of the family in Rāmeśvar evoke karuṇa rasa; Dvijvar's nationalist poetry arouses vīra and raudra; Harimohan Jha's humorous prose creates a field for laughter and satire; Harilata's devotional songs carry a current of bhakti and sweet devotional feeling; and the songs of R. C. and Mohan offer experiences of love, nature and emotional tenderness.

Dhvani — Behind the explicit narratives of many works lie implicit social meanings. Hunger is not merely a lack of food but an injustice embedded in economic structures. Marriage is not merely a domestic rite; it is an arena in which women's social position and caste standing are negotiated. Language is not merely a means of communication; it is a symbol of cultural freedom.

Vakrokti — Yatri's columns, Harimohan Jha's humorous prose, Shyamanand Jha's satire, the stories of Lalit and Dhirendra, and R. C.'s political poetry generate meaning through oblique expression, irony, satire and symbol.

Aucitya — Raman repeatedly asks whether there is propriety or congruence among a work's theme, characters, language, style, historical period and genre. Is it appropriate to call a story a novel, a humorous anecdote a short story, a translation an original work, or an influence a translation? These are all questions of aucitya.

Sādhāraṇīkaraṇa — The hunger, unemployment, marital suffering or cultural distress of one person acquires literary value when it becomes the experience of an entire community or age. In his examination of Dhirendra's stories, the critic explicitly shows how personal experience acquires a social context when it becomes an expression of the social mind.

Lokamaṅgala — Akhiyāsal's criticism does not separate literature from society. Service to the mother tongue, women's education, opposition to caste discrimination, the dignity of labour, the rights of the poor and national independence become important criteria of literary evaluation.

Foundations in Western Literary Theory

The formalist perspective — Plot, character construction, dialogue, atmosphere, narrative pace, symbol, repetition, lyricism and generic structure can be examined from a formalist standpoint.

The New Historicist perspective — Each work is read in relation to the powers and institutions of its time, language politics, the freedom movement, social reform, feudalism and economic change.

The Marxist perspective — Hunger, poverty, labour, feudal exploitation, policing and administration, capital, elections, unemployment and class divisions are fundamental questions in many chapters.

The feminist perspective — Nirdai Sāsu, Sumati and Chandragrahaṇ, Harilata's devotional songs, and the discussions of the stories of Kumar Ganganand Singh and Lalit raise questions concerning women's education, marriage, the body, desire, domestic labour, widowhood and social control.

The postcolonial perspective — The pressure of Hindi and English on Maithili, neglect of the mother tongue, the politics of spreading Devanagari, the rights of local languages and literatures, and linguistic plurality within nationalism are all subjects of postcolonial debate.

The existentialist and psychoanalytic perspectives — The discussions of stories by Lalit and Dhirendra analyse meaninglessness, loneliness,

unemployment, the unbearable burden of responsibility, sexual desire, self-alienation and social incongruity.

The reader-response perspective — Chapters on Harimohan Jha's humorous prose and Yatri's column-writing attend to reading communities, the dialogic nature of periodicals, the popularity of humour and the shaping of readers' tastes.

The Videha Parallel-History Perspective and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

The central principle of Videha's parallel history is that literary history is not solely the history of government recognition, awards, universities and celebrated authors. The following have an equal claim to a place in that history:

rare manuscripts;

books that have not circulated;

local journals and periodicals;

writers from rural communities;

workers in the service of their mother tongue;

forgotten editors;

poets writing under conditions of economic hardship;

the silence of female characters;

the suffering of farmers and labourers;

linguistic subordination;

cultural relations between Mithila and its diaspora.

The history of Maithili literature has always been a field of ideological conflict. On one side stands a 'mainstream tradition' centred on classical balance, institutional approval, Brahminical elitism and a polished presentation of the past. On the other stands the 'Videha parallel tradition', connected with the living pulse of the people, resistance by the oppressed and dispossessed, and realistic representation. According to the Navya-Nyāya theory of śabda-pramāṇa, truth is fractured wherever evidence is suppressed—as when the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī is concealed. Analysis of hetvābhāsa brings to light logical faults and ideological deception within literature. The principal achievement of Akhiyāsal is that it makes visible again numerous footprints buried beside the main road of Maithili literary history.

Part One: Achievements of Individual Chapters and Their Critical Appreciation

1. Maithili's First Storyteller, Pandit Shrikrishna Thakur, and Chandraprabhā

The collection's first essay is, in a sense, the germinal chapter of the entire work. It revises prevailing assumptions about the starting point of Maithili prose fiction. Ramanand Jha establishes the search for the 'first' as a critical undertaking: 'to investigate which servant of Maithili first set out upon the path of the development of fiction'. This declaration serves as the methodological manifesto for the whole collection.

Pandit Shrikrishna Thakur was born in 1750 into the Khaṇḍavalā lineage. He was the son of Pandit Maheshwar Thakur of Sarvasima and died in 1822. Among his principal works are Mithilā Tīrthaprakāś, Nārī Dharmaprakāś, Śūdra Vivāha Paddhati, Vaitaraṇīdānam, Śuddha Nirṇaya and Śivapūjā Pradīpikā. To establish him as Maithili's first storyteller and Chandraprabhā as its first work of fiction, the critic draws upon genealogies, dates, the teacher–disciple tradition and corrective evidence, including a clarification of Jayakant Mishra's mistaken designation of the work as Chandrabhāgā. This correction from Chandrabhāgā to Chandraprabhā reveals the archival care at the heart of the criticism.

The author establishes Chandraprabhā as an example of nineteenth-century Maithili prose and an early collection of stories. The manuscript was deteriorated, only parts of the work survived, and it was published in 1939, many years after its author's death. Its structure rests on a dialogue between teacher and disciple, and on the movement from one story into another. Through dialogues between teacher and female disciple, moral maxims are upheld; the writing provides an outstanding example of an older prose style. In this respect it is connected to the Pañcatantra, Vidyapati's Puruṣa-Parīkṣā and the Sanskrit tradition of narrative and subsidiary tale—a distinctly classical understanding of literary continuity. The stories are instructive, event-driven and directed towards moral conclusions.

Judged by the Indian principle of aucitya, the work's importance lies not in the complexity of its plots but in its historical role in early Maithili prose. From a Western standpoint, this is an inquiry into origins, central to historicist criticism. From the Videha parallel-history standpoint, the chapter is particularly important: the critic himself emphasises the 'unavailability' of Chandraprabhā and incorporates the labour of preserving a rare manuscript, editing it and publishing it into literary history. Restoring marginalised, undocumented and lost texts is the

essential principle of parallel history, and Ramanand Jha gives it an early articulation here.

2. Pandit Jivach Mishra, Maithili's First Novelist, and Rāmeśvar

The author regards Rāmeśvar, published in 1916 by Mithila Printing Works, Madhubani, as Maithili's first original novel. Pandit Jivach Mishra was born in 1863. His father's untimely death disrupted his education, yet he undertook serious study of Sanskrit, Maithili, Hindi and Urdu. The discussion presents his life, literary inspiration and commitment to his mother tongue at length. His resistance to the expansionist dominance of Hindi and opposition to the hereditary leadership of the Maithil Mahasabha constitute a living record of the colonial-era struggle for linguistic identity.

At the novel's centre are hunger, the ostentation of śrāddha rites, indebtedness, police and administrative oppression, false accusations, imprisonment, family disintegration and the social origins of crime. Rameshwar borrows money to perform his father's śrāddha, is forced to sell his home and property, and ultimately becomes a bandit after suffering police persecution; his wife Parvati attempts suicide by jumping into the Kamala River. Rameshwar is not a criminal by birth: economic compulsion, feudal power and administrative deceit push him onto the path of crime. From a Marxist perspective, his criminality is in fact the outcome of class exploitation. Karuṇa rasa begins in the novel's opening scene: dogs fall upon food thrown away after the śrāddha, while hungry children look on from a distance. According to the critic, the dialogue is simple and natural, while the creation of atmosphere is effective.

From a Marxist–New Historicist perspective, this is one of the finest essays in the book. The critic interprets Rāmeśvar not merely as an aesthetic object but as a text of resistance standing against structures of power: the Darbhanga Raj, the Maithil Mahasabha and the Hindi Sahitya Parishad. Jivach Mishra's fearlessness and his ‘exposure of the intrigues of the literary establishment’ correspond remarkably with New Historicism's analysis of power and discourse. In the Videha parallel-history perspective, Rāmeśvar records not the history of a royal court but that of a starving rural family. This searing realism is a golden summit of Maithili prose.

3. Rasbihari Lal Das and the Novel Sumati

Sumati (1918) is an early attempt to establish the genre of the modern novel in Maithili. The author foregrounds Rasbihari Lal Das's sense of the scarcity of literature, his connection with Mithilā Darpaṇ and his resolve to provide a novel in his mother tongue. The novel's principal concern is how wasteful expenditure, dowry and the desire for ostentatious display ruin families, and how an educated woman, Sumati, uses her intelligence

to save a household on the verge of collapse. The episode of a marriage arrangement involving Sahelola Babu and Manorath Labh, borrowing to entertain the wedding party and the eventual destruction of the family's entire property offer vivid examples of social realism. On arriving at her marital home, Sumati sells her jewellery to free the family from debt and thereby establishes a model for society.

The chapter also incorporates the judgments of earlier literary historians. Jayakant Mishra considers the plotting, characterisation and narrative technique immature, while accepting that the subject is appropriate for the Maithili novel. Radhakrishna Chaudhary calls it the first successful attempt to write a modern Maithili novel. A particular strength of this essay lies in its sensitivity to intertextuality. Jivach Mishra had considered the use of Hindi verse in Sumati ‘an indication of the inability of the Maithili language and its poet’; Ramanand Jha recovers this contemporary critical exchange. It is precisely this criticism of criticism that gives the essay theoretical depth. From the Indian principle of aucitya, the introduction of Hindi poetry into Maithili prose breaches linguistic propriety. Ramanand Jha acknowledges this flaw as ‘stylistic looseness’, but gives precedence to the period's impulse towards social awakening and judges the work important. The balance between admitting defects and defending historical and social importance signals the critic's maturity.

The chapter distinguishes historical importance from artistic achievement by using the criterion of aucitya. A work may be the ‘first’, but that fact alone cannot make it artistically complete. From the standpoint of Videha parallel history, Sumati documents a transition in genre: an uncertain but significant step by Maithili prose from the ethical tale towards the modern social novel.

4. Janardan Jha ‘Jansidan’ and Nirdai Sāsu

This chapter brings marriage arrangements, go-betweens, the bride's family, relations between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law, and the domestic oppression of women to the centre of literary discussion. Jansidan's (1872–1951) Nirdai Sāsu was serialised in Mithilā Mihir in 1914. Its plot draws on social circumstances, and its portrayal is so natural that events seem to unfold before the reader. The work offers a moving depiction of the silent woman Sharada, who endures persecution by her mother-in-law Anuprani and sister-in-law; it demonstrates the hostility to women's education and patriarchal cruelty of the society of that time. Astrologer Chintamani Jha's decision to educate Sharada, the unconventional giving of his daughter in marriage, and Anuprani's opposition express a conflict between older and newer values, which the critic terms ‘the outcome of an intense social consciousness’.

In examining Jansidan's Śaśikalā, Kaliyugī Sannyāsī and other works, the critic skilfully presents disagreements over genre: Harimohan Jha called Nirdai Sāsu a ‘farce’, while others called it a ‘novel’. One major achievement is that Ramanand Jha himself revises his initial doubts about the forcefulness of Jansidan's personality on the basis of an analysis of the available writing: in the light of his socially reformist consciousness, that personality emerges as forceful. This self-correcting critical method testifies to the intellectual integrity of the work.

From a feminist standpoint, the story reveals the complex forms of domestic power. Women are persecuted not only by men but also by other women who have internalised patriarchal conventions. The mother-in-law, herself a product of the system, becomes its representative in oppressing the daughter-in-law. The helplessness of the newly married woman is the source of karuṇa rasa. Read through the theory of dhvani, the festivities of marriage carry an underlying hard history of the bride's economic valuation, the family's prestige and patriarchal control. From a Marxist standpoint, the work can be read as a call to resistance against a system that ‘divides Mithila's society into compartments and exploits it’; it is an excellent literary expression of class consciousness and social contradiction.

5. Pandit Janardan Jha: A Forgotten Worker for Literature

In this short essay, among the book's most important from a theoretical standpoint, Ramanand Jha supplies the conceptual basis for his entire critical project: the principle of ‘two categories of literary figures’. Writers of the first order, such as Vidyapati, become so dominant that they overshadow writers of the second order, whom people eventually forget. An image of the enormous waters of the Ganga and Kosi rivers, alongside the local importance of smaller streams linking village to village, makes the argument unforgettable. The actual river of history receives its water not only from great currents but also from modest tributaries; Pandit Janardan Jha represents one of those unseen streams.

The author's argument is that the main current of literature is formed not solely by celebrated writers but by the sustained labour of numerous local and ‘second-rank’ literary workers. Because Pandit Janardan Jha's writings became rare, his name all but disappeared from history. His short epic Jānakī Pariṇaya depicts famine, Janakpur, Sita's birth, the breaking of the bow and marriage rites. Its linguistic simplicity, originality and cultural detail make it useful evidence for literary history.

This principle bears a remarkable resemblance to Western accounts of canon formation and the literary economy. Ramanand Jha argues that the absence of publishing opportunities, irregular periodicals and limited

public access have deprived many writers of visibility. This is the central proposition of the Videha parallel-history paradigm. Indeed, the whole essay can be regarded as a manifesto anticipating the Videha movement.

6. Pandit Trilochan Jha of Bettiah: A Forgotten Devotee of the Mother Tongue

Trilochan Jha (1878–1938) appears as a translator, poet, storyteller and narrative writer, biographer, essayist, social worker and institutional founder. He possessed extraordinary organisational ability; the essay brings to light the institutional history of the Subodhinī Sabhā and the Maithili movement. Through praise of the motherland and songs of the past, he sought to awaken a dormant Maithil society. Lines of his such as 'Caṇḍi tohar Mithilā deś' infused public consciousness with energy. He also translated the Bhagavad Gita into Maithili verse under the title Śrīmadbhagavadgītādarś, a mark of his vigorous scholarly outlook.

A comprehensive evaluation is difficult because his writings lie scattered through different magazines: the critic repeatedly concedes that 'very little material is available'. The surviving work nevertheless attests to his profound devotion to the mother tongue and its literature. He regarded language and literature as foundations of social advancement. He challenged the indolence, self-absorption and cultural indifference of Maithil society and encouraged a sense of collective responsibility for recovering Mithila's standing. From a postcolonial perspective, service to the mother tongue extends political freedom: self-rule without linguistic freedom is incomplete. Here the acknowledgement of scant evidence makes visible the essential crisis of parallel historiography—archival poverty.

7. Yadunath Jha 'Yaduvar': A Pioneer Poet of National Consciousness

Through Mithilā Gītāñjali (1923), Yaduvar (1888–1935) established the consciousness of the national freedom struggle in Maithili poetry. His verse combines the voices of Mithila, Maithili and Indian nationalism. He broke with older conventions, inaugurated writing on national concerns and was the first to free Maithili poetry from the bonds of musical rāga. His Maithilī Sāhitya Digdarśan is regarded as Maithili's first research-based essay, offering an overview of its literature.

In naming Yaduvar 'a pioneer of national consciousness', Ramanand Jha advances a specific proposition: 'Yaduvar's writing initiated a strong tradition of national and nation-building literature by wiping away the religious coating from the tendency to engage with one's time and place that had begun with Kavishwar Chanda Jha.' The image of 'wiping away the religious coating' conveys a delicate historical awareness of the

secularisation of literary tendency and provides an excellent example of New Historicist attention to changing dispositions.

He calls upon educated Maithils to awaken from indifference towards their mother tongue, inertia and subordination to outside languages. The vīra rasa of his poetry is not confined to the battlefield: it is the heroism of a linguistic and cultural struggle. To write in one's mother tongue, publish literature and awaken Maithil society was, for him, national service. From a postcolonial perspective, Yaduvar sees feelings of linguistic inferiority as the product of a colonial mentality. In Videha parallel history, his poetry is a record of a movement for linguistic freedom running alongside political mobilisation.

8. Chhedi Jha 'Dvijvar': The Poet-Freedom Fighter

This chapter refutes the common accusation that Maithili writers stood apart from national consciousness. Dvijvar was born in 1893 in Bangaon, Saharsa. He was not merely a writer of patriotic poetry: responding to Gandhi's call, he resigned from government service, joined the struggle for independence and was imprisoned four times. Comparing Yaduvar and Dvijvar, the critic draws a fine distinction: because Yaduvar remained in government service, his activity was confined to literature, whereas Dvijvar resigned his post and worked in both politics and literature. To call the union of 'creative talent and the capacity for agitation in a single individual' a 'rare event' affirms the inseparability of literary art and action, consonant with the idea of committed literature.

Swadeshi, the spinning wheel, economic independence and village life form the foundation of his nationalism. Poems such as Carakhā Caumāsā clearly echo the Swadeshi movement. For him the nation is no abstract power but the combined life of villages and homes, rivers, fields, people and nature. His poem Chūtahar strikes against untouchability and feudal cruelty: 'For what sin have I become untouchable? The clay is one; the potter is the same.' This line forcefully attacks social inequality, giving the excluded a discernible voice in his poetry. The conjunction of karuṇa and raudra with vīra rasa elevates the poems above mere propagandistic verse. In Videha parallel history, Dvijvar breaks down the artificial division between literary creation and political action.

9. The Sensibility of Kumar Ganganand Singh's Stories

Kumar Ganganand Singh's career in fiction extends over a long period, from 1924 to 1965. Stories such as Manuṣyak Mol, Vivāh, Bihāṛi, Paṇḍitputra, Pañc Parameśvar and Āmak Gāchī raise questions of social reform, harmful marriage customs, untouchability, education and village life. Manuṣyak Mol depicts the heartrending reality of a child widow's suicide. Bihāṛi expresses a consciousness of emancipation from

untouchability: oppressed people refuse to perform unpaid labour for the local gentlemen and go on strike. The author locates Singh's importance as a storyteller in his choice of plots not from Purāṇas or religious scriptures but from his contemporary society. Breaking with the didactic tradition of the subsidiary tale and attacking the living deformities of society is his achievement.

In this essay Ramanand Jha sets out a sequence linking 'experience, expression, truth and communication': 'In the expression of experience there is a communication of truth, and in the communication of truth the reality of life and one's surroundings finds expression.' The word vyañjanā, suggestion or evocation, recalls Ānandavardhana's theory of dhvani: literature's significance lies not simply in its literal meaning but in what is suggested beyond it. The criterion of being 'validated by the passage of time' likewise accords with the idea of enduring value. In resolving a dispute over the authorship of Manuṣyak Mol and Vivāh—Jayakant Mishra and Shreesh had attributed them to Bhol—Ramanand Jha offers a sociological reading of language use. In Bihāṛi, the Hindi-influenced speech of Raudi and Kamati suggests the 'influence of other languages on the uneducated'. This is a fine critical recognition of linguistic realism.

The portrayal of female characters, child marriage, widowhood and domestic persecution produces karuṇa rasa. The language of the stories is simple, accessible to ordinary people and humorous. In a short story such as Āmak Gāchī, the absence of unnecessary elaboration and a mysterious ending bring the work close to the modern short story.

10. The Vaishnavism of the Poet Harilata

The distinctive feature of this essay is Ramanand Jha's recovery of the literary practice of a woman writer, the poet Harilata (Modavati, born 1903)—an early indication of the gender-oriented recovery pursued by Videha parallel history. Her life story—marriage at the age of only four, widowhood in youth and her husband's mental derangement, a time when 'reading was forbidden to women' and she nevertheless 'learnt her letters in secret from her mother-in-law and others'—is a narrative of struggle for female identity.

Her Bhajanamālikā (1937) is an outstanding example of Vaishnava devotion to the personal, manifest deity. Ramanand Jha shows, from the standpoint of the poetics of devotion, that Harilata's 'worship of the manifest form because the formless is unattainable' accords with Vaishnava tradition. The child Krishna rocking in a cradle, toddling in the courtyard and grazing cows in Vrindavan is portrayed with 'sweetness to the ear and abundance of rasa'. Her songs contain the six elements of devotion—ānukūlya-saṅkalpa, the resolve to do what pleases God; prātikūlya-varjana, the rejection of

what opposes divine will; rakṣaṇa-viśvāsa, trust in divine protection; goptṛtva-varaṇa, the acceptance of God as guardian; ātmanikṣepa, self-surrender; and kārpaṇya, humility—as well as mādhurya rasa. She transformed the unbearable pain of child widowhood into the sweetness of Krishna devotion. This is a classical discussion of the rasas of devotion and parental affection.

11. The Themes of Poet Shyamanand Jha

The author reads Shyamanand Jha's poetry in four categories—national, social, cultural and practical—and presents him as a 'poet conscious of his age'. The poet's anger is not personal; it arises from the political subjugation, economic inequality, linguistic humiliation and social apathy of his time. Behind an outburst such as 'Jari jāy jeṃ jajāte karite paṭāy kī ho' lies the pitiful condition of his immediate environment. The poems sharply satirise the feudal class's indifference to political, social and cultural decline in the Gandhian period, epitomised by the attitude 'Whoever becomes king, what difference does it make to us?'

His poetry calls for India's independence, the protection of Maithili, economic equality, social awakening and cultural regeneration. Satirising the upper classes for their blind devotion to English and Hindi, he writes of people abandoning their own adornments and clothing, hiding their ears at the mention of Vidyapati and rolling about in enthusiasm for 'hats and neckties'. This is a declaration against cultural enslavement. The line 'For service to the country it is difficult to produce even a small coin … yet they become generous when a coin is to be taken' is a finely pointed irony, an example of the obliqueness of expression in Kuntaka's theory of vakrokti. From a rasa perspective it combines pathos and heroism with disgust towards feudal conduct. From a Marxist standpoint it is direct literary criticism of the concentration of wealth and class inequality. His depiction of poverty, clothing, food, shelter and family responsibilities testifies to his social vision.

In Maithil Sandeś and Maithilī Gīt-Candrikā, love of country is joined to folk culture. His practical songs encompass sohar birth songs, naming rites, initiation, marriage, the bridal chamber, samdāun farewell songs and other life-cycle rituals, creating a poetic archive of popular life. The combination of love, humour, devotion and folk customs broadens the range of his poetic subjects.

12. Babu Lakshmipati Singh and Maithili Journalism

In this essay Ramanand Jha crosses the boundaries of literary criticism and enters the history of journalism. He treats Lakshmipati Singh (1907–1972) as a writer, editor, publisher, cultural worker and founding figure in Maithili journalism—'not confined to a single genre, nor to a single

language'. Singh devoted throughout his life to his mother tongue the impulse towards literary creation he had received as a disciple of Pandit Shrikrishna Thakur, and worked ceaselessly to connect migrant Maithils with Mithila.

His contribution was by no means confined to his own writing. Editing and publishing rare works, encouraging authors and building a reading public through magazines helped develop a Maithili public sphere. He advocated freeing Maithili journalism from political and economic servitude so that it could become self-reliant. He made clear that Maithili periodicals ought not to be a literary monopoly: they should also convey news and matters of public concern. The essay's final portion offers a far-sighted analysis of the future of Maithili newspapers. Without advertising, correspondent networks, editorial policy and a base of readers, Maithils themselves would remain compelled to depend on newspapers in other languages. This media-sociological insight was ahead of its time.

From a reader-response perspective, journalism establishes a living dialogue between writer and reader. In Videha parallel history, editors are not incidental figures on the margins of literature but makers of memory and readership.

13. The Lyric Poetry of Kavichudamani Madhup

The analysis of Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup''s lyric poetry is the collection's most sustained essay in the theory of rasa. 'A song rests upon emotion; its impact upon the heart is immediate, and it sets the strings of affective disposition vibrating.' This account is a Maithili restatement of Bharata's production of rasa and Abhinavagupta's savour of aesthetic emotion. The notion of poetic practice that 'awakens nāda-brahman' is connected to the Indian philosophy of sound. Citing Manipadma's description of Madhup as one who can polish a worn half-rupee into gold and then a diamond, and as a voice sounding in the tradition of 'Vidyapati and Mira', Ramanand Jha gives him a place at the summit of the lyric tradition.

Madhup's world of song combines love, devotion, domestic life, ideals of womanhood, social education and cultural rites. A song is not merely something to read: it is to be memorised, sung and experienced communally. This assessment of the 'indispensability of song in folk life'—in courtyards, on verandahs, in fields and threshing grounds, in bridal chambers and at the Simaria ghat—is an excellent application of Bhaṭṭanāyaka's principle of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa. At a time when Maithil youth were infatuated with the melodies of film songs, Madhup wrote Maithili songs to cinematic tunes to save the language from disappearance. From Videha's parallel-history standpoint, this was a democratic, grassroots attempt to keep the language of the people alive. He also

rendered the narrative of festivals such as Vaṭ-Sāvitrī into song, removing their dryness, making the story accessible to women and children, and placing Maithili on the tongues of ordinary people. This demonstrates the social usefulness of song.

From the standpoint of rasa, Madhup's songs combine devotion, the love of separation and compassion. In terms of dhvani, they implicitly sustain women's social roles, the moral discipline of the family and the preservation of folk tradition within an ideal of domestic life.

14. Madhup and the Tradition of Bhaṭṭikāvya

This essay is among the book's boldest theoretical chapters, exploring the relationship between Sanskrit's pedagogic poetic tradition and Maithili poetry. In Bhaṭṭikāvya, narrative serves not only aesthetic enjoyment but also the teaching of grammar, figures of speech, metre and language. A modern Maithili version of this instructional tradition is discerned in Madhup's poetry. From the standpoint of Indian poetics, the union of knowledge and pleasure is the chapter's central principle. If poetry becomes nothing but instruction, it loses rasa; if it becomes nothing but entertainment, its educational purpose disappears. Madhup's achievement lies in reconciling these competing demands.

Taking the composition of Kobar-Gīt as his point of departure, Ramanand Jha poses a fearless question: 'Why is poetry written?' He offers a plain answer: 'fame' and 'material reward'; no poet stands entirely outside these two conditions. This assertion challenges purist idealism about literature by revealing its material and economic foundations, a distinctly Marxist insight into the sociology of literature. The circumstances are these: under pressure from Kumar Ganganand Singh and Rajpandit Baldev Mishra, Madhup was obliged to write a 'bridal-chamber song' for Maharaja Kameshwar Singh so that a school's grant would not be lost. Calling this song 'a sign of the compulsions of its age', Ramanand Jha confronts a difficult ethical and aesthetic question: why does a poet write against his own spirit? He concedes that Madhup's 'poetic power was so intense that even an uncongenial subject could acquire a divine and moving quality'. This is an honest discussion of the tension between purpose and talent. From a Videha parallel-history standpoint, the chapter situates Sanskrit and Maithili not in a master–servant relationship but as traditions engaged in dialogue.

15. The Fictional World of Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran'

Ramanand Jha regards Kiran (1906–1989) as a representative short-story writer of the transitional period of the third decade, turning away from the imaginative world associated with Vidyapati towards the reality of *desil vayna*, the speech of the people. His fictional world (*Chandragrahan*,

Dharmaratnakar and *Samajak Chitra*) addresses social inequality, caste, labour, religious obscurantism, power, women and the moral struggles of human beings. The critic discovers in these writings a critical light that pierces the darker layers of society. *Chandragrahan* exposes licentious conduct and fraud carried out under cover of superstition concerning a natural phenomenon; *Dharmaratnakar* lays bare the anguish of oppressed tenants such as Ram Kisan and the hypocrisy of the gentleman styled Dharmaratnakar Babu Saheb.

Images of 'naked children shivering in the winter cold', 'young women desperately seeking to cover their modesty', and 'the country's future running about to find the money for school fees' communicate the pathos of realist writing with particular intensity. From the standpoint of reader-response theory, Ramanand Jha's subtle recognition of the moment of rupture in Kiran's stories—when 'in setting hopes upon the contrivance of imagination, one's connection with reality is lost'—also reveals an awareness of the Formalist concept of defamiliarisation.

From a Marxist standpoint, Kiran exposes the gulf between the privileged and working classes; from a Dalit standpoint, the Brahmanical determination of social standing comes under question; and from a feminist standpoint, women's lives become not simply examples of a domestic ideal but a sphere of independent social experience. Kiran's fiction is concerned with the public good, but it does not merely preach: the contradictions of his characters, irony and social dissonance give the stories life. Within Videha's parallel history, Kiran reveals inequality *within* Mithila instead of offering an encomium to Mithila.

16. The Women Characters of *Chandragrahan* in the Light of the Maithili Novel

This is the collection's most modern chapter in critical orientation, studying the changing forms of female characterisation in the Maithili novel. From Rajani and Sushama in Kiran's *Chandragrahan* (1932) to the women of *Rupa* (1988), Ramanand Jha analyses a line of development against the historical background of social reform movements: 'As reformist and movement-based consciousness became more pronounced in the social environment, its influence continued to be felt in the construction of characters in novels.' This is a compelling New Historicist reading of the dialectical relationship between literature and society.

Under the influence of social reform, education and modern consciousness, the women in *Chandragrahan* leave behind conventional silence and acquire new personalities. Women's inner desires, love, separation, bodily awareness, decisions and social responsibilities become active elements of the narrative; a parallel arrangement of the

surroundings and the heroine's interior condition creates psychological depth. From a feminist perspective, this is the collection's most progressive essay. Ramanand Jha exposes the hypocrisy of the learned class, whose 'entire body of instruction is meant for other people', and which would deny education even to women abducted amid the bustle of fairs. To discern the 'aggressiveness of the creator's personality' in the making of characters is a form of expressionist criticism. The attempt to regard women not merely as embodiments of sacrifice or guardians of the family, but as human beings with desires and ideas of their own, is significant.

17. Professor Harimohan Jha and His *Charchari*

Charchari, by Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), Maithili's most popular writer of humour and satire, is not a book belonging to a single genre. Its contents include stories, one-act plays, shadow plays, letters, conversations on the veranda, conversations by the pond, farces and cultural essays. The use of *charchari*, a mixed vegetable preparation, as a metaphor for this diversity of genres is a clever reading of the title. Ramanand Jha identifies these works neither as conventional stories nor as essays but as instances of an independent genre of conversational prose, *gapp*. Harimohan Jha's literary world—including *Charchari*, *Khattar Kakak Tarang* and *Pranamya Devata*—established this genre in Maithili. Through humour, satire and oblique expression, he attacked hollow scholarship, orthodoxy and social hypocrisy. From the viewpoint of rasa theory, a piece such as 'Panch Patra' is a fine instance of the pathetic sentiment, presenting with poignancy the changing emotional relationship between husband and wife and the consciousness of an age. The farce 'Relak Jhagra' humorously portrays a family unsettled by the winds of modern education.

Harimohan Jha's greatest achievement was the creation of an extensive Maithili readership. He gave literary form to the Maithil community's disposition towards humour and attracted readers to literature. Indian *hasya-rasa* and Western approaches to satire converge in these works; the hybrid genre of *gapp* bridges oral popular narration, classical wit and modern printed literature.

At the same time, this essay is among the collection's most openly dissenting assessments. Ramanand Jha fearlessly identifies a limitation of a canonical author such as Harimohan Jha: 'After reading most of his compositions, there is no blossoming of thought, no intellectual churning; one is merely tickled, and once the laughter has passed, its effect vanishes.' This anticipates the courage of Videha's alternative paradigm in reassessing canon-centred judgement: popularity is not necessarily synonymous with literary excellence.

18. The Column Writing of the Poet Yatri

By establishing the columns of Yatri (Nagarjun) as a literary form, Ramanand Jha brings out the intimate relationship between Maithili journalism and literature. The early periodicals aimed to serve the mother tongue and to remedy social abuses; readers' columns opened an intellectual exchange among writers, editors and readers. In columns such as 'Yatra Tatra Sarvatra', 'Yatkinchit' and 'Chintan-Anuchintan', Yatri commented on the immediate concerns of politics, society, economics, language and culture. The essay also traces his development of satirical figures such as 'Choa-Kaka'. That 'not even the smallest occurrence should remain beyond the boundary of Yatri's keen vision' acknowledges the satirist's all-encompassing gaze.

Through his columns Yatri sharply criticised the ruling class's verbal sophistry, the economic neglect of the Mithila region and linguistic imperialism. Even while respecting Hindi as a language of communication, he opposed taking away the rights of Maithili and other languages in its name. The columns' language is pointed, satirical, conversational and character-centred. As an enlargement of the range of genres, this essay turns literary history towards newspaper prose and identifies a new model of political satire and social thought in Maithili prose.

19. The Poet R. C.

R. C. Prasad Singh (born in 1911) wrote in both Maithili and Hindi, but his principal identity in Maithili is that of a lyric poet. Through *Shephalika*, *Matik Dip*, *Pujak Phul* and *Suryamukhi*, his poetic journey extends from nationalism, nature and love to social consciousness and popular rights. His early songs speak of national unity, independence, sacrifice and India's composite culture: he calls for the construction of a new age and for India's millions to be bound together in unity. In his later poems the exploitation of Mithila, language rights, floods, political corruption and popular anger become increasingly vocal.

From a Formalist standpoint, R. C.'s distinguishing qualities are lyricism, imagery, alliteration, sensory perception and a gentle flow of feeling. This essay is particularly strong in its account of sensory experience: taste and fragrance in night-flowering jasmine and blossoms, touch in the breeze, and a fusion of taste, scent and sound in a stream of perfume. The analysis of mingled sensory impressions is a refined instrument of modern Western poetry criticism; from an Indian perspective, it belongs to the discussion of *guna* and *riti*, especially the quality of sweetness, and of figures of speech. The movement from *Shephalika* to *Suryamukhi* traces a poet's

development from personal aesthetic sensibility towards social consciousness.

20. Upendra Thakur ‘Mohan’ and His Poetry

One of the collection's most extensive essays is devoted to Mohan, the enduring lyricist of ‘Ayal Vasant’. Songs such as ‘Ayal Vasant’ were memorised from generation to generation, making poetry a living communal memory beyond the classroom. Ramanand Jha here adopts an autobiographical mode: his recollection of hearing the song in Shriramchandra Babu's class during his student days, and of Mohan's ceaseless industry in the office of *Mihir*, lends the criticism the intimacy of a memoir. Mohan's poetic world brings together memory, nature, springtime, lyricism and the struggle of life.

Mohan's love for the mother tongue—expressed in such lines as ‘The mistress of the household gropes in darkness: shall we light a lamp in the temple?’ and ‘Do not invite the village; invite Belahi’—reveals a sharply felt linguistic identity. The question ‘When Maithili is endangered, reduced to a brinjal in a winnowing basket, what is nationality? What is patriotism?’ brings the relationship between language and national identity into dispute.

Mohan's life was shaped by financial deprivation, the struggle for education, migration, unemployment and labour in a printing press. His poetry is consequently not merely about the sweetness of nature, but about an effort to preserve beauty within a working life. In Videha's parallel history, a printing-house proofreader too is a maker of literary history: rather than merely correcting other people's books, he safeguards the linguistic forms, spelling and literary culture of his time.

21. Upendranath Jha ‘Vyas’: A Purist Writer of Short Fiction

Upendranath Jha ‘Vyas’ (born in 1917) advocated a pure, indigenous and natural form of Maithili. Discussing *Vidambana* and *Bhajana Bhajale*, Ramanand Jha raises the theoretical question of quantity versus quality: ‘If, despite writing basketful after basketful, a writer cannot establish any value in life … that writer is declared irrelevant even within his lifetime.’ This is a Formalist, quality-centred assessment. The test by which Vyas's stories remain ‘not stale but freshly made’—their enduring freshness—accords with a conception of lasting literary value.

His stories are distinguished by their use of language, social satire, moral irony and the living dialogue of village life. Purism for him was not simply the selection of words, but cultural resistance: amid the influence of other languages, conserving Maithili's own syntax, idiom, pronunciation and emotional terrain meant conserving the mother tongue's identity. In

Formalist terms, the language of his fiction helps construct the social position and mentality of its characters; in postcolonial terms, his insistence on linguistic purity symbolises self-respect.

22. Pandit Rajeshwar Jha: Personality and Achievement

Rajeshwar Jha (1922–1977) was exceptionally active as a researcher, playwright, short-story writer, editor, publisher and founder of institutions. His writings are divided into three categories: research, historical-mythological writing and creative literature. His scholarly works include *Mithilaksharak Udbhav O Vikas*, *Maithili Sahityak Adikal* and *Avahattak Udbhav O Vikas*. In assessing him, Ramanand Jha makes a serious methodological declaration: 'It is first necessary to understand a writer's personality; without understanding that personality, it is impossible to penetrate the layers of his work.' This is an explicit case for biographical criticism. Despite poverty, Rajeshwar Babu published books every year and encouraged others to write. Ramanand Jha values this inspirational work more highly than his literary output, remarking that, 'On the balance, the weight of his personality would prove greater.' This evaluation of an institution-builder anticipates the institution-centred perspective of the Videha movement.

The chapter is distinguished by its refusal to stop at praise. The critic regards several of Rajeshwar Jha's conclusions—including his periodisation of literary history, his dating of the beginnings of Maithili literature to a millennium before the Common Era, and his claims concerning Avahattha—as lacking adequate evidence. Judged by standards of propriety and historical method, this is one of *Akhiyasal*'s most balanced critical studies: it is possible simultaneously to respect an individual's labour and subject his conclusions to rigorous scrutiny.

23. Transitional Lives in the Social Settings of Lalit's Stories

Ramanand Jha reads Lalit's fiction as a literary record of the disillusionment that followed Independence, a transition between pre-Independence hopes and subsequent disappointment: 'The ray of hope turned into despair; the bough broke and fell.' Electoral trickery during the first elections, blind self-interest, the naked dance of money, caste and casteism, counterfeit leaders, impoverished voters and corrupt development projects become the realities of his social setting. This is a strong example of Marxist-realist criticism, treating literature as a changing reflection of national and political reality.

From a Marxist perspective, a story such as 'Pratinidhi' exposes the conflict between the privileged ruling class and the poor who lack rights; an educated young man who once despised physical labour eventually acknowledges its value. 'Ladai' analyses divided consciousness, the

intellectual outlook of two generations and their sense of responsibility. Stories including ‘Ramjani’, ‘Mrityunjay’, ‘Overload’ and ‘Du Chitra’ address the breakdown of tradition, the crisis of employment, religious hypocrisy, bodily needs, the burden of existence and the remnants of feudal attitudes.

24. The Social Context of Dhirendra's Stories

The chapter opens with a theoretical account of social context and contains one of Ramanand Jha's most sophisticated propositions: ‘Sociality is a shape hammered out upon the anvil of society; the anvil is the conflict between the individual mind and the social mind.’ This dialectic of individual and collective mentality is an intellectual high point of the book, formed at the intersection of Marxist dialectics and psychoanalytic criticism. Personal experience becomes social when it awakens the reader's dormant experiences and comes to represent a collective consciousness. The ability of a writer's experience ‘to become society's experience, to become society's mirror’ is an exceptionally clear Maithili formulation of the theory of art as reflection.

Dhirendra's stories portray educated unemployment, patronage, corrupt recruitment, the devaluation of truth, the appropriation of the poor person's labour and class exploitation. The symbols in ‘Manukh Bikait’ (‘People for Sale’) and ‘Gidh’ (‘Vulture’) express the commodification of humanity and the strong preying on the weak in modern society. In a Marxist reading, the vulture becomes a figure for capital and power consuming the bodies of workers. Through the process of *sadharanikarana*, the private suffering of an unemployed young man becomes the anguish of millions of young people. The critic's treatment of ‘eyes filling with tears’ as both a common element and a device of craft is a subtle Formalist observation, although he himself admits uncertainty over the boundary between sentimentality and technique.

25. Prabhas's Journey as a Short-Story Writer

The collection's last and longest essay concerns Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary (born in 1941). Here Ramanand Jha undertakes a broad study of influences, analysing the effects of Sanskrit, English and Bengali literature on Maithili fiction. This methodological application of comparative literature lifts the book from historical description to the level of theoretical comparison.

Treating Prabhas's two-decade career as a gradual journey, the critic examines changes in the writer's understanding of life, social consciousness and mode of narration. He traces a course from the storyteller's ‘setting out from home and moving about the village to an eventual condition of emotional detachment and a consciousness of inactivity’. Economic

deprivation, society's selfishness, neglect of the poor and the inhumanity of the supposedly respectable classes become central subjects. Prabhas's stories move from individual experience towards broader social structures: characters initially appear to be victims of their circumstances but gradually begin to recognise the structures of exploitation. This developmental account of an author's consciousness demonstrates the critic's mature perspective. Ending the collection with this contemporary storyteller completes the movement from the 'first' to the 'present'. In Videha's parallel-history perspective, Prabhas's fiction records not history's triumphant proclamations but the everyday defeats, struggles and attempts at self-preservation of neglected human beings.

The Second Half: Chapter-by-Chapter Limitations, Contradictions and Incompleteness

The second half of this evaluation is devoted entirely to the limitations, weaknesses and methodological difficulties of *Akhiyasal*. Such critical severity does not diminish the work; it is a necessary part of taking its historical importance seriously. Only after unsparing examination of the limitations of a pioneering book can its successors establish their own direction.

1. Limitations of the Chapter on Shrikrishna Thakur and *Chandraprabha*

The argument for recognising *Chandraprabha* as the first short-story collection is important, but the surviving manuscript is incomplete. Without the full text, the dates of composition, variant readings and the author's final version, the designation 'first' must be awarded cautiously. The chapter emphasises historical significance more than close individual analysis of the stories' plots, characters, narrators, ordering of time and linguistic structures. Resemblances to the Sanskrit tradition of didactic tales are identified, but the distinctions among similarity, influence, adaptation and originality are not always maintained. From the Videha perspective, one might add that the fictional world of *Chandraprabha* developed largely under the shadow of Sanskrit texts; it lacks realist portrayals of grassroots popular life and the deprived classes, while the dominance of moral instruction obstructs the realisation of *rasa*. The prestige of being early should not obscure a work's artistic limitations.

2. Limitations of the Chapter on Jivach Mishra and *Rameshwar*

The chapter makes a strong case for *Rameshwar* as the first original novel, but establishing priority would require systematic comparison with contemporary publication lists, advertisements, manuscripts and other possible novels. Explaining Rameshwar's criminality through social

compulsion is reasonable; yet his moral responsibility for distrusting his wife, his violent disposition and his active participation in robbery receives too little scrutiny. His reunion with his son and change of character at the end are exceptionally abrupt. Without a gradual process of psychological transformation, the resolution appears melodramatic. One may also argue from a Marxist standpoint that the novelist ultimately converts class struggle into moral idealism through Rameshwar's change of heart, extinguishing revolutionary possibilities with the waters of reformism. The woman character Parvati suffers, but her independent perspective remains limited.

3. Limitations of the Chapter on *Sumati*

The chapter engages with earlier critics, but offers insufficient direct analysis of *Sumati*'s complete plot, character structure, viewpoint and use of language. There is a tension between its historical importance and its designation as a 'successful modern novel': when the plot is disorganised, characters indistinct and presentation immature, the criteria for 'success' must be made explicit. From a feminist perspective, a serious problem lies in presenting the sole purpose of Sumati's education as rescuing her declining marital household and freeing the family from debt. The woman possesses no independent agency or aspiration; she remains confined to the role of saviour of a patriarchal family. Repeated interventions by the narrator in the guise of an 'appropriate speaker' interrupt the novel's structural autonomy, a phenomenon Jaikant Mishra calls 'immature craft'. The essayistic language, crowded with Tulsidas's *chaupais*, constitutes a poetic defect. A concern with social reform is not in itself proof of artistic superiority: the mode of presentation, complexity of character and internal necessity are equally important, however significant the subject matter.

4. Limitations of the Chapter on *Nirdayi Sasu*

The story raises the problem of women's oppression, but presenting the mother-in-law simply as a 'cruel' villain may reduce the larger structure of patriarchy to an individual's harshness. What social pressures, economic fears, marriage arrangements and notions of prestige have themselves shaped the mother-in-law? These questions are not sufficiently explored. The daughter-in-law is made an object of pity, while her resistance, will, solidarity with other women and possibilities of an alternative life remain underdeveloped. The heroine Sharda is almost silent throughout; here the troubling question posed by subaltern studies—'Can the subaltern speak?'—is fully relevant. Flat and one-dimensional characterisation is also a limitation from a structuralist point of view. To represent a woman only as a victim is itself a limitation of feminist representation.

5. Limitations of the Chapter on the Forgotten Literary Worker Janardan Jha

The chapter's archival purpose is commendable, but its account of a life, based on limited materials, relies on inference in several places. Although the cultural details of *Janaki Parinay* are discussed, its metre, language, figures of speech, narrative pace and characterisation receive too little sustained consideration. The enthusiasm to restore a forgotten writer to recognition occasionally pushes the work's actual artistic limitations into the background. Giving someone a place in history is not the same as assigning that person high literary value.

6. Limitations of the Chapter on Trilochan Jha

The critic himself acknowledges that materials relating to Trilochan Jha are scant and scattered. Consequently, the chapter becomes more a reconstruction of biography than a work-centred criticism. Love of the mother tongue, organisational activity and social service are amply praised, but the particular writer's style, linguistic choices, command of genres and contradictions of thought remain indistinct. The call to recover Mithila's ancient greatness sometimes moves towards romantic nostalgia: an appeal to emotional unity that obscures divisions of caste and class is liable to be impracticable. The criticism of caste inequality, women's exclusion and social orthodoxy was as necessary as the invocation of ancient glory.

7. Limitations of the Chapter on Yaduvar

Greater weight is given to Yaduvar's nationalist and linguistic consciousness than to poetic form, metre, suggestion, imagery, oblique expression and individual voice. Poetry devoted to awakening the mother tongue may at times turn declarative and didactic. In a line such as ‘Jai Jai Jayati Maithil Jati’, literal denotation predominates and suggested meaning is limited; the chapter does not clearly distinguish propaganda from poetry. The ‘Maithil’ community is treated as homogeneous, with scant attention to differences of caste, class, gender and region. It is questionable to suppose that linguistic identity is experienced in precisely the same way by all Maithils. The lack of a concrete critique of Mithila's feudal order amid excessive idealism is another weakness.

8. Limitations of the Chapter on Dwijavar

The active life of this poet and freedom fighter is undoubtedly important, but the heroism of his biography overshadows an independent criticism of the verse. Political activity does not of itself establish poetic excellence; closer analysis of language, metre, symbols, ideological complexity and artistic durability was required. Nationalism is treated as an unquestioned

value of public welfare, though nationhood itself can contain inequalities of class, caste, religion and gender. The swadeshi movement and spinning wheel have social meaning, but their relationship to modern economic structures is not critically examined. *Chhuthar* speaks of the oppressed, yet remains within the sphere of Gandhian reform rather than revolutionary consciousness, and metrical constraint sometimes diminishes its representation of reality.

9. Limitations of the Chapter on Kumar Ganganand Singh

The critic himself demonstrates that many of the storyteller's works are driven by a predetermined aim: first a moral conclusion is fixed, then characters and events are added to illustrate it. The story becomes an example instead of communicating life's natural complexity. In several stories, extended spans of time, unnecessary turns, excessive elaboration of events and complete resolutions at the end weaken their effects. Ramanand Jha also acknowledges that the narrative threads of 'Vivah' and 'Bihari' spread beyond control. Despite a commitment to social reform, the abolition of caste comes to a halt halfway: stories opposed to untouchability do not bring Dalit characters to full social equality, while reform in 'Bihari' ultimately depends on the benevolence of the upper class. From the standpoint of Navya-Nyaya, 'Panch Parmeshwar' exhibits a contradictory reason: while advocating reform, it also instructs the village council that 'the amusements and pleasures of feudal lords and landlords should not be disturbed'. Thus it speaks of reform while defending the comfort of exploiters. There are also few women characters.

10. Limitations of the Chapter on Harilata

The limitation of this essay is that the critic attributes Harilata's suffering in widowhood merely to 'turning towards God', overlooking its potential for social criticism. A powerful feminist reading was possible: her struggle to learn letters secretly against child marriage, widowhood and the denial of education to women. Instead, the discussion largely confines itself to Vaishnava devotion. Psychoanalytic criticism might further ask whether devotion here became a means of escaping social reality, transforming material suffering into spiritual mysticism and postponing the question of social rights. The essay does not bring into view the tension between these two possible readings: a classical enjoyment of devotional *rasa* and an overlooked potential for social resistance.

11. Limitations of the Chapter on Shyamanand Jha

The chapter bears the title 'The Subject Matter of Poetry', and the critic expressly says he examines content rather than the artistic dimension. As a result, metre, images, suggestion, syntax, figures and style do not receive

adequate evaluation. The vision of cultural revival idealises 'Aryan culture', without substantially raising questions of caste, women's rights or social exclusion within that culture. Foreign influence or the use of Devanagari is sometimes portrayed as a conspiracy, though changes in language also have complex social, printing-related and educational causes. Satire occasionally hardens into personal anger and slogans, weakening the suggestive power of poetry.

12. Limitations of the Chapter on Lakshmipati Singh and Journalism

This chapter is more an affectionate remembrance of a personality than an institutional history of journalism. There is little factual information about a periodical's circulation, financial base, subscribers, distribution, editorial policy or readers' responses. The roles of women readers, rural subscribers, printers, distributors and contributing writers remain unclear. The boundary between journalism and literary editing also needed to be sharper: news, opinion, literature, institutional announcements and social campaigns each required analysis of their distinct operations. Moreover, although the critic recognises that Maithili journalism stands on 'crutches', his explanation stresses economic distress more than intellectual emptiness or an absence of courage to question those in power.

13. Limitations of the Chapter on Madhup's Song-Literature

The chapter emphasises the social and cultural usefulness of Madhup's songs, but pays insufficient detailed attention to their tunes, metrical measures, rhythms, singing traditions and performance contexts. The images of womanhood built around Savitri, wifely devotion and domestic ideals may reinforce patriarchy. Women's learning and moral strength are praised, but questions of self-determination, desire and alternative lives remain limited. The popularity of a song and its literary endurance are different standards: being learnt by heart is an important sign of poetic value, but not the only proof.

14. Limitations of the Chapter on the *Bhattikavya* Tradition

The relationship between Sanskrit *Bhattikavya* and Madhup's verse is intriguing, but more explicit evidence is required concerning direct textual similarity, imitation, transformation and independent development. Seeing instructional poetry as a continuous tradition may flatten the differences among historical periods, languages and communities of readers. The task of teaching grammar or figures of speech may sometimes restrict poetry's freedom to realise *rasa*, and the chapter does not test this tension rigorously enough. The most serious issue concerns the doctrine of appropriateness (*auchitya*). To justify writing 'contrary to one's own spirit' on the ground that 'society is greater than

the individual' leaves unanswered a fundamental violation of emotional appropriateness. What is the aesthetic standing of writing produced under pressure of practical ends? The theoretical answer is unclear. Under the strictest standard of Videha epistemology, the court-sponsored 'Kobar Git' testifies to the writer's subjection to royal patronage. When a poet of the people's language is compelled to praise royalty, both epistemic courage and the authority of verbal testimony suffer—although Ramanand Jha's sympathetic interpretation as a 'compulsion of the age' also acknowledges the historical complexity of this episode.

15. Limitations of the Chapter on Kiran's Fictional World

Praise of Kiran's social progressivism sometimes displaces formal analysis of his stories. Plots, narrators, viewpoints, temporal structures, silences and symbols required fuller study. Uniformly applying Marxist or reformist conclusions to every story can diminish internal contradiction, ambiguity and multiplicity of meaning. From what social position is Kiran's 'Maithil perspective' constructed? Do Brahmins, Dalits, women, farmers and townspeople all see things alike? These questions are rarely asked. In Navya-Nyaya terms, the reasoning in *Chandragrahan* may contain the fallacy of an inconstant reason (*savyabhichara hetvabhasa*): to refute superstition, it resorts to a melodramatic and communally coloured argument involving 'abduction by someone of another religion'. If there had been no abduction, would the superstition surrounding bathing in the Ganges have become justified? This looseness of reasoning weakens the story's progressive purpose.

16. Limitations of the Chapter on the Women Characters of *Chandragrahan*

The novelty of the women characters is recognised, yet they are often evaluated according to traditional standards of sacrifice, chastity, love and family duty. Female desire and bodily consciousness are discussed, but the questions of women's economic independence, property rights, education, labour and participation in public life remain limited. A clear distinction was needed between the male gaze of the narrator and a female character's own voice: making a woman speak through an author is not equivalent to a woman's autonomous self-narration.

17. Limitations of the Chapter on *Charchari*

The argument for recognising *gapp* as an independent genre is imaginative, but its necessary features, boundaries, structure and differences from story, essay and farce are not systematically determined. Harimohan Jha's humour sometimes turns into ridicule of characters rather than a subtle examination of social deformities. Where its targets

are principally vulnerable people, villagers, women or orthodox figures, the edge of satire against power may be blunted. From a Marxist perspective it is also argued that he attacks society's upper surface—ritual practice and pedantry—without striking at its feudal economic foundations; laughter alone cannot heal society's serious wounds. Ramanand Jha himself quotes earlier critics, Professor Jaidev Mishra and Dr Jaikant Mishra, who held that Harimohan Babu demolished old values but failed to establish any new, constructive values for living. This raises the question of an intellectual void, and the related danger that an excessive zeal to find faults can damage elevated cultural values without proposing alternatives.

18. Limitations of the Chapter on Yatri's Columns

Columns address events of their own moment, and many references grow obscure with the passage of time. Without complete issues of the journals, relevant news and readers' reactions, their meanings may remain incomplete. Yatri's sharp first-person voice makes the columns lively, but personal judgement, satire or anger can sometimes dominate analysis. The form of column-writing also imposes limitations: it may not move beyond immediate reactions to provide a long-term theoretical alternative. All three columns ran for relatively short periods, making it difficult to trace a sustained developmental history of Yatri's thinking in this form. Critical editing and chronological publication of the surviving material are necessary.

19. Limitations of the Chapter on R. C.

R. C.'s extensive poetic career is brought under the principal headings of nationalism, love for Mithila, social consciousness and lyricism, though a subtler analysis of intellectual change across its successive phases was possible. The early nationalist poems can be declarative. At times the noise of fervent nationalism suppresses the finer realities of internal class struggle and marginalised communities in Mithila, drawing the verse towards propaganda. Descriptions of Mithila's natural beauty are idealised, even though floods, poverty and migration were equally present realities. The influence of *Chhayavad* and mysticism is mentioned, but there is little comparative study of how R. C. transforms these influences into specifically Maithili experience.

20. Limitations of the Chapter on Mohan

The chapter is full of the intimacy of recollection. This makes the personality vivid but reduces critical distance. There is considerable description of hardship, poverty and generosity, but relatively little systematic examination of the poetry collections, textual variants, metre, imagery, language and development of ideas. The popularity of ‘Ayal

Vasant' cannot represent an entire poetic personality. Consideration of lesser-known, weaker or more reflective poems would have yielded a more balanced evaluation.

21. Limitations of the Chapter on Upendranath Jha 'Vyas'

Linguistic purism can serve the mother tongue's dignity, but in its rigid form it may reject linguistic mixture, neologisms, urban experience and changing speech. A language changes alongside a living society: not every foreign word is impure, nor every old word pure. Who determines the standard of purity? This question must be asked. While the storyteller's command of language is praised, the limitations of plot, character, psychology and social vision receive less equal attention. Language is a major component of fiction, not its sole component. A critical contradiction also arises here: Ramanand Jha considers it a virtue that Vyas's stories are 'not particularly influenced by contemporary life' and remain 'unaffected by the distortions of a changing age', while elsewhere —in his discussions of Ganganand Singh, *Chandragrahan*, Lalit and Dhirendra—he treats sensitivity to reality and involvement with the social environment as supreme values. This clearly reveals instability in his evaluative criteria, to be examined more fully in the later discussion of methodological limitations.

22. Limitations of the Chapter on Rajeshwar Jha

This chapter is already highly critical, but its refutational tone sometimes becomes unduly severe. Greater consideration could have been given to the researcher's historical circumstances, available sources and methodological limitations of his time. The shortcomings of his unsupported conclusions are shown, but no complete alternative scheme of periodisation or Avahattha's development is offered. After the account of personality and work, the catalogue of errors is extensive, while there is little close reading of his better scholarship, useful compilations or successful plays. Criticism should restore valuable elements, not merely express disagreement. In addition, emotion born of personal attachment in the account of Rajeshwar Jha's death affects critical distance.

23. Limitations of the Chapter on Lalit's Stories

The chapter gathers together many social, political, existential, sexual and religious questions. The resulting breadth sometimes pushes the specific form and beauty of individual stories into the background. To explain sexual desire as a biological need, liberated from religious and moral restraints, can be one-sided: desire is also connected with power, consent, gender inequality and emotional relationships. Stories are treated as direct documents of their age, yet literature is not a replica of reality. It is a form

created through selection, imagination, symbol and narrative perspective. The thoughts of the author and those of a character must be distinguished.

24. Limitations of the Chapter on Dhirendra's Stories

The theoretical proposition concerning social context is significant, but restricting each story to class exploitation, unemployment and social injustice can diminish its psychological, linguistic and symbolic dimensions. The symbol of the 'vulture' is effective, yet a single fixed class meaning is emphasised in place of its many possible meanings. More analysis was required of language, dialogue, silence, the narrator's distance, the uncertainty of endings and the reader's participation. The social relevance of a subject is not automatically proof of artistic accomplishment.

25. Limitations of the Chapter on Prabhas's Journey in Fiction

The word 'journey' suggests progressive development, but not every writer's creation advances in a straight line from an early phase towards maturity; a later work is not necessarily better than an earlier one. Biography and social environment are treated as the main causes of the development of fiction, while literary influences, editorial policies of periodicals, readership, experiments in genre and self-criticism are less clearly explored. Determining Prabhas's entire fictional outlook on the basis of selected stories may yield only a limited conclusion. Unpublished, rare and less successful stories are also necessary for a comprehensive evaluation.

Methodological Difficulties: A Detailed Examination of the Work's Overall Limitations

Limitation 1: Inconsistency of Compilation and the Absence of Structural Unity

The work's first and most fundamental limitation lies in the circumstances of its composition. These twenty-five essays were written independently between 1972 and 1989, for different journals, on different occasions, and with different readerships in mind. Their assembly into a 'book' produces an underlying inconsistency. Some essays centre on individuals (Trilochan Jha and Rajeshwar Jha), some on particular works (Sumati and the female characters in Chandragrahan), some on a genre (column writing), and others on a literary tendency (Yaduvar and Dwijvar). No single theoretical framework binds the essays together. The reader must consequently negotiate continual shifts of context. From a formalist standpoint, this is structural looseness: the book lacks a logically developing sequence of ascent and descent. The chapter order appears broadly to follow the

chronology of the writers' births, but even this ordering is inconsistent. Without any stated rationale, some essays are extremely short and others very long. The introduction, statement of method, and conclusion expected of an organised monograph are missing. Each essay simply ends with the source and date of its original publication, exposing the collection's assembled character. The chapters are unequal in extent, method, and critical depth.

Limitation 2: Repeated Admissions of 'Unavailability' — A Foundational Weakness in the Criticism

The book's gravest methodological difficulty is that, in almost every early essay, the critic himself acknowledges the 'unavailability' of the primary work. On Chandraprabha, he states that an adequate study and analysis could not be undertaken, principally because the text was unavailable. On Trilochan Jha, he notes that very little material is available; on Yaduvar, that comparatively little research has been done to date; and on the forgotten Janardan Jha, that compositions once published in journals are no longer readily accessible.

A profound contradiction follows. If the critic did not have access to the primary work, on what grounds could he assess its aesthetic qualities? In many places the criticism depends, in effect, upon secondary sources: Jayakant Mishra's history of Maithili literature, Karunakant Jha's research dissertation, or quotations supplied by other critics. Ramanand Jha himself observes that, for most subsequent critics, the limits of the material available to them are those of Jayakant Mishra's history. Yet that charge applies, at least in part, to his own practice. From the standpoint of text-centred criticism, this is a fundamental weakness: criticism without the text.

From the standpoint of Videha's parallel-history paradigm, the limitation is especially instructive. The first duty of a parallel history is archival preservation and the provision of access to texts: without making original works widely available in digital or printed form, their reassessment is impossible. Ramanand Jha repeatedly points to this necessity, suggesting that further light will be shed when the works become generally accessible. But he cannot himself complete that archival task; in the pre-digital period it would have been virtually impossible through individual effort alone. It is precisely this archival gap that the Videha movement seeks to address through its e-journal, book collections, and the documentation of genealogical registers. Thus Akhiyāsal's greatest limitation is also the source of its greatest historical significance: it names a gap whose closure becomes the responsibility of later generations.

Limitation 3: Unstable Standards of Value and Internal Contradictions

From a rigorous theoretical standpoint, the work's most troubling defect is the instability of its evaluative standards. A quality regarded by Ramanand Jha as paramount in one essay may be praised in its opposite form in another:

(a) In his discussions of Ganganand Singh, the female characters of Chandragrahan, Lalit, and Dhirendra, he treats sensitivity to contemporary realities, engagement with the social environment, and the representation of the life of the age as supreme values. Yet he praises Vyas's fiction precisely because it is not especially influenced by contemporary life and remains unaffected by the distortions of a changed age. This is a direct contradiction: engagement with reality is sometimes a virtue, and sometimes its absence is a virtue.

(b) Harimohan Jha's humour is assigned a lower value because it does not stimulate reflection, whereas Madhup's songs are valued highly for their immediate effect upon the heart and the pleasure they afford. Yet songs, too, often depend not upon intellectual deliberation but upon emotional immediacy. Immediate effect is thus sometimes a merit (in song) and sometimes a fault (in humour).

(c) An expedient, self-contradictory composition such as a kobar song is defended on the ground that society is greater than the individual. But judged in the light of Kshemendra's conception of propriety (aucitya), writing contrary to one's own inner convictions violates the fundamental propriety of feeling. Here the critic does not establish theoretical clarity.

This instability arises because Ramanand Jha does not adopt a single, explicitly defined theoretical commitment. Depending on the occasion, his approach is impressionistic, sociological, biographical, or formalist. Such methodological eclecticism offers flexibility on the one hand, but on the other renders evaluation unpredictable and inconsistent.

Limitation 4: Insufficient Theoretical Inquiry — The Absence of a Systematic Critical Vocabulary

Although such concepts of Indian poetics as rasa, dhvani, suggestion (vyañjanā), and propriety (aucitya) are implicitly present in Ramanand Jha's criticism, he nowhere uses these classical models as clearly articulated theoretical instruments. Terms such as ‘suggested’, ‘communication’, and ‘based on feeling’ do occur, but the names of Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta, Kuntaka, Kshemendra, and Bhaṭṭanāyaka, together with systematic applications of their theories, are absent. Nor is there any sustained invocation or considered use of Western literary theory. This creates an ambivalent situation. Theoretical economy makes the criticism

readable, communicative, and accessible to the general journal reader, an advantage consonant with the essays' original periodical setting. At the same time, however, it deprives the work of academic depth. The criticism is descriptive and evaluative but less consistently theoretical and analytical. The strong theoretical foundation required to give a parallel literary history lasting legitimacy remains underdeveloped.

Limitation 5: A Restricted Perspective — Male-Centred and Caste-Centred Selection

From sociological and postcolonial perspectives, a serious limitation of the work is the narrowness of its social outlook. Twenty-four of the twenty-five essays are devoted to male authors; only one is devoted to a woman writer, Harilata. Even there, the discussion of Harilata is largely confined to Vaishnava devotion. Women appear chiefly as characters or sources of inspiration, and much less frequently as independent authors, editors, and critics. An autonomous literary history of women writers remains insufficiently developed.

Likewise, almost all the authors examined belong to a particular social stratum. Dalit, most-backward, minority, and folk-tradition creators in Mithila, including the anonymous makers of oral literature and singing and performance traditions, are largely absent from this parallel history. Questions of caste and class arise, but the voices of Dalit communities speaking for themselves receive little space. The limitation is partly historical, for the surviving archives of the period were predominantly produced by upper castes. Nevertheless, measured against the democratic inclusiveness of the full Videha parallel-history paradigm, Akhiyāsal remains incomplete. Parallel history means more than recovering forgotten upper-caste writers; it calls for the restoration of the entire margin, including Dalit, female, folk, and oral traditions. In this wider sense Ramanand Jha's project is a beginning, not a completed undertaking.

Limitation 6: Textual Authenticity and Editorial Errors

The authenticity of the verse and prose passages cited in the book remains uncertain. Since the critic himself acknowledges that many works were scattered among journals or unavailable, comparison of quoted passages with their original texts was often impossible. Their accuracy could be further compromised in later editing and printing; the available copy also contains inconsistent spelling and typographical errors. Dependable parallel history requires the disciplines of textual criticism and critical editing, which are understandably absent from this pioneering work. Claims such as ‘first’ and ‘original’ demand especially rigorous textual collation, manuscript research, and publication history. Where

conclusions rest on limited materials, conjecture must not take the place of evidence.

Limitation 7: Excessive Praise Born of Personal Affection and a Lack of Critical Distance

In a number of essays, particularly those concerning Lakshmipati Singh, Mohan, and Rajeshwar Jha, the critic's personal closeness to the subject turns literary criticism into the equivalent of an affectionate memorial tribute. His recollections of Mohan, the emotional portrayal of Lakshmipati Singh's smiling face, and the grief expressed over Rajeshwar Jha's death are moving. Nevertheless, such intimacy can compromise critical distance. From an objective critical standpoint this is a bias towards praise that affects the impartiality of judgement. The courage to criticise displayed in the essay on Harimohan Jha is not consistently present throughout the collection. At times biography outweighs examination of the work, while thematic content overshadows beauty of form.

Limitation 8: The Incomplete Theorisation of the Parallel-History Paradigm

Finally, viewed through Videha's parallel-history paradigm, the most fundamental limitation is that Ramanand Jha practises the idea of parallel history without explicitly presenting it as a theory. His distinction between 'two categories of writers' comes closest to such an account. Yet it remains a supplement to, rather than an alternative to or challenge against, the mainstream canon represented by Jayakant Mishra's history. Ramanand Jha repeatedly treats Mishra as an authoritative foundation and relies on the information he supplies, whereas the essential work of a parallel history is to interrogate the founding assumptions of the mainstream canon itself. In short, Akhiyāsal provides materials for a parallel history while leaving its theoretical foundations incomplete. It enlarges the canon without dismantling the power structures through which a canon is formed. It is this unfinished task that the Videha movement seeks to pursue through an explicitly articulated theory, institutional archiving, and democratic inclusion.

It must also be said that love of the mother tongue energises the book. Yet at several points this affection becomes cultural triumphalism or excessive suspicion of outside influence, although languages always develop through contact, mixture, and change; national or cultural allegiance, too, is sometimes treated as a value exempt from questioning.

Overall Critical Judgement

The Book's Principal Achievement

Akhiyāsal's most important achievement is its illumination of forgotten regions of literary history. The book asks:

Where should the true beginnings of Maithili fiction be located?

What distinguishes literary influence from translation?

What constitutes evidence for identifying a work as the 'first'?

How does a rare manuscript disappear from history?

What roles do journals, editors, and publishers play in the creation of literature?

Why was the contribution of Maithili writers to the national movement forgotten?

Does the popularity of humour conceal social injustice?

What is the relationship between linguistic purity and linguistic development?

Why did the lives of the poor, the unemployed, and workers fail to change after independence?

How does the writer's individual experience become social experience?

These questions raise the book above the level of an ordinary collection of biographical and bibliographical sketches.

From the Standpoint of Indian Literary Theory

The book extends rasa into the social sphere. Compassion does not simply mean shedding tears over a character's suffering; it also means investigating the social causes of that suffering. Heroism is found not only on the battlefield but also in defending one's mother tongue, standing for truth, and resisting exploitation. Humour is not merely entertainment: it can remove the masks worn by authority and convention. According to the theory of dhvani, the indirect social meanings within many works are more important than the narrative stated explicitly. The principle of aucitya provides grounds for testing historical claims, generic classifications, and the credibility of characters. Yet measured against classical criteria, the limitations of many early mainstream works also become visible: excessive moralising and preaching disrupt rasa; the predominance of literal denotation weakens dhvani; and poetry reduced to slogans destroys the obliqueness of expression associated with vakrokti.

From the Standpoint of Western Theory

New Historicist and Marxist tendencies are particularly pronounced in Akhiyāsal. Literature is connected with power, money, caste, language, institutions, and social movements. The readings of Lalit's and Dhirendra's fiction disclose existential crisis, class exploitation, and the modern individual's experience of meaninglessness. A feminist perspective is present, particularly in the discussions of Nirdayi Sāsu, Sumati, and Chandragrahan; its full possibilities, however, such as a resistant reading of Harilata, remain undeveloped. From a postcolonial perspective, alienation from the mother tongue, the dominance of Hindi and English, and the expulsion of Maithili from public life are abiding concerns of the book.

From Videha's Parallel-History Perspective

Akhiyāsal constructs an alternative genealogy of Maithili literature. It includes:

Shrikrishna Thakur and Chandraprabha;

Jivach Mishra and Rameshwar;

Rasbihari Lal Das and Sumati;

literary workers such as Jansidan and the forgotten Janardan Jha;

devotees of the mother tongue such as Trilochan Jha;

poets of awakening such as Yaduvar and Dwijvar;

a struggling woman poet such as Harilata;

editors such as Lakshmipati Singh;

lyric poets such as Madhup and Mohan;

columnists such as Yatri;

linguistic purists such as Vyas;

institution builders such as Rajeshwar Jha; and

socially engaged storytellers such as Kiran, Lalit, Dhirendra, and Prabhas.

All find a place within the same expansive history. It does not regard Mithila merely as a centre of royal dynasties or scholastic learning. Its Mithila includes hungry children, oppressed daughters-in-law, unemployed young people, exploited farmers, an educated class estranged from its mother tongue, printing-press workers, and forgotten editors.

Conclusion: The Dignity of Beginnings and the Legacy of What Remains Unfinished

Akhiyāsal matters not because it delivers a final verdict but because it invites a reconsideration of the history of Maithili literature. The book places alternative questions before established literary history. Its author sees not only the glittering peaks of literary achievement but also the buried bricks beneath them: damaged manuscripts, old journals, hungry characters, a neglected language, and forgotten literary workers. From Pandit Shrikrishna Thakur to Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary, the gradual emergence of realism, nationalism, and social reform in literature becomes visible. At the same time, when this entire body of writing is subjected to the rigorous tests of parallel history, Navya-Nyāya epistemology, and Western and Indian poetics, its structural, ideological, and theoretical limitations are also exposed: survivals of feudal mentality, the limits of reformism, patriarchal prejudice, and the absence of authentic voices from dispossessed communities. Literature can become fully parallel and credible only when it frees itself from state patronage and feudal dominance, and represents the reality of the exploited with complete epistemological courage and without recourse to fallacious reasoning.

Its strength lies where:

the author searches for archives;

corrects received errors;

restores forgotten writers to view;

reveals connections between social life and literature;

maintains critical distance even while offering praise; and

places the mother tongue and the lives of ordinary people at the centre of literary history.

Its limitations appear where:

conjecture replaces evidence;

biography outweighs analysis of the work;

subject matter conceals the beauty of form;

evaluative standards become unstable;

national or cultural commitments become unquestioned values; and

the voices of women, Dalits, and the lower classes are not granted sufficient independence.

The conclusion of the overall assessment is that Akhiyāsal is a progressive, courageous, and historically indispensable work of its period, whose originality is inseparable from its limitations. Its virtues—its courage in investigating literary beginnings, its recovery of forgotten authors, its sociological insights, its original conception of 'two categories of writers', and its attempt to free Maithili literary history from a person-centred canon and make it people-centred—establish it as a milestone in Maithili criticism. At the same time, its limitations—the inconsistencies inherent in compilation, the unavailability of primary texts, unstable standards of value, inadequate theoretical inquiry, a restricted perspective, doubts about textual authenticity, personal bias, and the incomplete theorisation of parallel history—are not merely individual failings. They are consequences of the structural constraints of a period limited by print, lacking digital resources and institutional support.

It is this duality, the inseparability of strengths and limitations, that makes Akhiyāsal a precursor of the Videha parallel-history movement. The gaps identified by Ramanand Jha—public accessibility, archival preservation, and reassessment—become a historical responsibility for succeeding generations. In this sense the work's greatest limitation is also its greatest legacy. The 'eye' in its name evokes a vision courageous enough to see forgotten texts, while 'sāl' evokes the age in which the means of fulfilling that vision were not available; the name Akhiyāsal itself suggests this duality. Even so, the book holds a significant place in Maithili criticism and literary history. It opens the closed doors of history and declares that literature's true tradition is not simply a list of celebrated names; it is a shared parallel history of memory, forgetting, struggle, language, institutions, readers, and the lives of the people.

Appendix: Contents of the Collection, with Original Publication Sources

No.	Chapter / Author under Discussion	Original Publication Source and Date
1	Maithili's First Storyteller, Pandit Shrikrishna Thakur, and Chandraprabha	Mithila Mihir, 18 August 1985
2	Maithili's First Novelist, Pandit Jivach Mishra, and Rameshwar	Mithila Mihir, March 1977

No.	Chapter / Author under Discussion	Original Publication Source and Date
3	Rasbihari Lal Das and the Novel Sumati	Hālchāl, issue 1/1986
4	Janardan Jha ‘Jansidan’ and Nirdayi Sāsu	Mithila Mihir, June 1982
5	Pandit Janardan Jha: A Forgotten Literary Worker	Mithila Mihir Daily, 29 July 1985
6	Pandit Trilochan Jha (Bettiah): A Forgotten Devotee of the Mother Tongue	Bhākhā, September 1987
7	Yadunath Jha ‘Yaduvar’: Pioneer Poet of National Consciousness	Bhākhā, 1988
8	Chedi Jha ‘Dwijvar’: Poet and Freedom Fighter	Mithila Mihir Daily, August 1985
9	The Narrative Sensibility of Kumar Ganganand Singh	Mithila Mihir, 24 October 1976
10	The Vaishnavism of Poet Harilata	Maithili Prakāsh, September 1972
11	The Subjects of Poet Shyamanand Jha	Mithila Mihir, 23 November 1975
12	Babu Lakshmipati Singh and Maithili Journalism	Basāt, inaugural issue, 1984
13	The Lyric Poetry of Poet Chudamani Madhup	Mithila Mihir, October 1987
14	The Bhaṭṭikāvya Tradition and Madhup	Mithila Mihir, issue 12/1987
15	The Fictional World of Kanchinath Jha ‘Kiran’	Mithila Mihir, May 1977
16	The Women Characters of Chandragrahan in the Context of the Maithili Novel	All India Maithili Literary Council, 1989
17	Professor Harimohan Jha and His Charchari	Maithili Academy Patrikā, March 1984
18	Poet Yatri's Column Writing	Mithila Mihir
19	Poet R. C.	Maithili Academy Patrikā, 1982
20	Upendra Thakur ‘Mohan’ and His Poetry	Maithili Academy Patrikā, 1989
21	Upendranath Jha ‘Vyas’: A Purist Storyteller	Mithila Mihir
22	Pandit Rajeshwar Jha: Life and Works	Mihir, 1978

No.	Chapter / Author under Discussion	Original Publication Source and Date
23	The Transitional Life of the Social Milieu in Lalit's Stories	Mihir, 1975
24	The Social Context of Dhirendra's Stories	June 1988
25	Prabhas's Journey in Fiction	Mithila Mihir, 1986

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4. Gajendra Thakur, A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature. Videha: The First Fortnightly Maithili E-Journal, Part 1. https://www.videha.co.in/new_page_1.htm

5. Gajendra Thakur, A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature. Videha: The First Fortnightly Maithili E-Journal, Part 27. https://www.videha.co.in/new_page_27.htm

6. Gajendra Thakur, A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature. Videha: The First Fortnightly Maithili E-Journal, Part 28. https://www.videha.co.in/new_page_28.htm

7. Gajendra Thakur, A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature. Videha: The First Fortnightly Maithili E-Journal, Part 90. https://www.videha.co.in/new_page_90.htm

8. Gajendra Thakur, Collected Writings. Videha: The First Fortnightly Maithili E-Journal. https://www.videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm

9. Periodicals in which the original essays first appeared: Mithila Mihir, Mithilāmod, Bhākhā, Maithili Academy Patrikā, Basāt, Hālchāl, Maithili Prakāsh, and commemorative publications of the All India Maithili Literary Conference/Council (1972–1989).

II. "Hiāol": Indian Poetics, Western Literary Theory and the Parallel-History Perspective

Abstract

"Hiāol": An Extended Critical Appreciation through Indian Poetics, Western Literary Theory and the Videha Parallel-History Perspective (Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman', Maithili Criticism, Akhiyāsal Prakashan, Lalganj, Sarisab-Pahi, Madhubani, 2012). Following Akhiyāsal, Besāhal and Bhajāral, Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman's fourth collection of criticism, Hiāol (2012), belongs to that rare tradition of Maithili criticism which, free of factional entanglements, takes texts, periodicals and archival documents as its evidence. The title itself announces the author's modest method: hiāol means something sounded out or estimated. This choice of word acknowledges the inexhaustible possibilities of research instead of indulging in self-congratulation; in the language of Kshemendra's theory of propriety, the title already plants the seed of propriety in the design of the work.

Keywords: Hiāol · Indian · poetics · Western · theory · parallel · history

"Hiāol": An Extended Critical Appreciation through Indian Poetics, Western Literary Theory and the Videha Parallel-History Perspective

—Gajendra Thakur

(Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman', Maithili Criticism, Akhiyāsal Prakashan, Lalganj, Sarisab-Pahi, Madhubani, 2012)

1. Introduction: The Book and the Significance of "Hiāol"

After Akhiyāsal, Besāhal and Bhajāral, Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman's fourth collection of criticism, Hiāol (2012), is part of that rare Maithili critical tradition which escapes factionalism and proceeds by treating texts, journals and archives as evidence. The book's very title announces a modest methodological position: hiāol—something sounded out, gauged or conjectured. Such a choice recognises the open-ended possibilities of investigation rather than proclaiming the critic's own greatness; in the vocabulary of Kshemendra's theory of aucitya, or propriety, the title itself contains the beginnings of prabandhaucitya, the propriety of an entire composition. In his author's note, Raman acknowledges that these essays do not belong to the category of entertaining literature: he has deliberately chosen difficult and relatively inaccessible subjects which deserve study but rarely attract public attention. In his cover note, Pandit Govind Jha remarks, with characteristic poignancy, that other well-known Maithili critics detect a stale smell in earlier literature and inherited tradition, whereas Raman enjoys "rice cooked from old grain, with fresh curd": they mistake his simultaneous preservation and fresh appraisal of tradition for ancestor-worship. In his foreword, Phoolchandra

Mishra 'Raman' rightly observes that the collection brings criticism and counter-criticism together; its purpose is not to diminish anyone's standing but to place questions on the table for discussion—"vāde vāde jāyate tattvabodhaḥ," understanding of truth arises through sustained debate.

The book contains seventeen chapters dealing with linguistics, literary history, counter-criticism, fiction, poetry, epic, folk ballad, folksong, journalism, natural disaster, cultural imperialism and linguistic colonialism. Its table of contents makes clear the sweep from Grierson's language studies to the new tactics of colonialism. These seventeen essays fall readily into three groups. First comes language thought and language politics: "The Study of Maithili and the Mithila Language"; "Ramanath Jha and the Mithila Language"; "Maithili Folksongs: Condition and Preservation"; and "The New Tactics of Colonialism." Second comes counter-criticism centred on writers and works: "Kiran as Counter-Critic"; "Reading Kanyādān through the Eyes of the Neglected"; "Lakshmipati Singh, an Unexamined Poet"; "Yatri's Language"; and "Unexamined Aspects of Manmohan Jha's Stories." Third comes a historical approach organised by genre and tendency: "The Contribution of Migrants to the Development of Maithili Journalism"; "Dīnābhadrī in the Maithili Folk Ballad"; "The Development of the Maithili Story: Some New Facts"; "Mithila's Earthquakes in Poetry"; "What Have You Taken Away, Mother Kosi?"; "The Age and the Maithili Epic"; "Social Consciousness in the New Song"; and "Current Trends in Maithili Poetry." In this threefold structure, the four aspects of Raman's critical personality—the linguist, textual critic, historian and counter-critic—appear together.

This is not a linear literary history but a gathering of parallel narratives which question accepted conclusions. The author's central concerns are to restore forgotten writers and works to visibility, expose the incompleteness of previous criticism, undo the artificial division between folk and cultivated literature, connect the development of Maithili language and letters with power, society, geography and history, and make visible the women, Dalits, labourers, migrants, villagers, flood victims and linguistic communities submerged beside the main historical narrative. Raman himself regards criticism as close scrutiny of the strengths and weaknesses of a work's language, craft, facts, subject matter, characters and characterisation. For him criticism is not merely a search for faults; it must also illuminate merits, and he attaches particular importance to the preservation and evaluation of literature, even beyond its creation.

2. Critical Method: Three Criteria

The present evaluation rests on three criteria.

The Basis in Indian Poetics

The first criterion is Indian poetics: Bharata's theory of the production of rasa; Anandavardhana's doctrine of dhvani or suggestion; Kuntaka's vakrokti, oblique expression; Kshemendra's account of aucitya or propriety; universalisation (sādhāraṇīkaraṇa); the perspective of public welfare (lokamaṅgala); and the Nyāya inquiry into the means of valid knowledge, especially the question of evidence from absence, which repeatedly surfaces in Raman's own reasoning. Rasa theory tests the emotional experience ultimately produced by a literary work. Dhvani reveals the social, political and cultural meanings latent behind explicit statements. Vakrokti attends to the beauty of creative language, symbols, irony and deviation from ordinary expression. Aucitya examines the mutual consistency of subject, language, character, occasion and conclusion. Universalisation asks how a private experience becomes a shared experience. The lokamaṅgala perspective evaluates literature's social usefulness, resistance to injustice and contribution to the public good.

The Basis in Western Literary Theory

The second criterion consists of Western theoretical approaches: postcolonial discourse, New Historicism, sociolinguistics, stylistics, textual criticism, reception aesthetics or reader-response theory, Marxist and subaltern perspectives, feminism, Dalit criticism and ecocriticism. A formalist approach analyses the arrangement of language, structure, symbols, repetition and modes of narration. Reader-response theory treats meaning not as fixed but as constituted through the reader's experience. A Marxist approach foregrounds class, labour, production, exploitation and structures of power. Feminist criticism examines women's silences, bodies, labour, education, rights and representation. Dalit and subaltern approaches seek the voices and self-representation of communities suppressed in history. A postcolonial approach brings to light the continuing colonial domination of language, education, knowledge and culture. New Historicism relates literary works to the power, institutions, economy and social conflicts of their time. Ecocriticism examines the interdependence of human beings, rivers, plants, animals and birds, land and catastrophe.

The Videha Parallel-History Perspective

The third criterion is the Videha perspective on parallel literary history. Alongside the histories of dynasties, royal courts, scriptures, established authors and institutions, it writes a history of ordinary lives; instead of institutionally sponsored canons, it places neglected, unexamined, folk-rooted and archivally attested traditions at the centre. Mithila in this perspective is not merely a political territory but a cultural geography. The

Maithili-speaking regions of India and Nepal belong to a long common cultural continuum. History belongs not only to kings but also to peasants, women, Dalits, Musahars, labourers, singers, journalists, migrants and victims of disaster. Literary history includes not just published books but oral transmission, ritual narratives, songs, unpublished manuscripts and forgotten authors; rivers, floods, earthquakes, migration and linguistic displacement become historical forces in their own right. This third criterion is especially apt for Hiāol, because many of its chapters—"An Unexamined Poet," "Unexamined Aspects," "Through the Eyes of the Neglected" and "Some New Facts"—are themselves exercises in constructing counter-canons, preliminary experiments in parallel historiography. Hiāol's central achievement lies precisely in this consciousness of parallel history. Approximately half of the present evaluation is devoted to the limitations of the individual chapters: that, too, accords with Raman's declared principle that criticism is not a testimonial of congratulation and need not be agreeable.

3. Chapter-by-Chapter Achievements and Critical Appreciation

3.1 The Study of Maithili and the Mithila Language

Tracing Western linguistic scholarship from Colebrooke (1801) to Grierson, the opening essay poses a piercing question: why, despite Maithili's long and uninterrupted literary tradition, was its grammar written so late? It dismantles Colebrooke's narrow assertion that Maithili was neither a rich language nor one possessing any distinguished poets. By setting the original English evidence before the reader, Raman shows how Beames (1872), Kellogg, Hoernlé (1880) and finally Grierson (1881) came to recognise Maithili as an independent language; the earliest Western investigations, however, were less studies of Maithili than exercises in gathering specimens for administrative convenience. The chapter is especially important from a postcolonial standpoint. Its citations of Macaulay's observation of 1835—why spend money on a language no one will study without government payment?—and Trevelyan's remarks of 1864 expose a language policy governed by colonial utility. The irony-laden proposition that "George Abraham Grierson was the first originator of Bihari identity" exemplifies the New Historicist insight linking the politics of naming with the politics of identity. Grierson appears here as a dual figure: on one hand, his survey lends Maithili a separate identity and authenticates its distinctive sound system and verbal morphology, helping free it from the shadow of Hindi; on the other, an aggregate label such as "Bihari" compresses linguistic diversity into a convenient category of colonial administration.

A major achievement of this chapter is its refusal to equate language development merely with the history of grammar-writing. Raman

explains Maithili's decline through sociolinguistic criteria of functional load and functional transparency: as a language loses ground in government, education, the courts, commerce and public life, its social capacity also diminishes. Archival indications of Maithili as an administrative language under the Karnata rulers, Nepalese state records, and the celebrated remark addressed to Bholalal Das—"If Maithili is recognised, Mithila will come alive..."—reveal the political underside of the making of Bihar. The distinction between traditional and pedagogical grammar, and the discussion of the five levels of pedagogical grammar, are among the most systematic presentations of their kind in Maithili. From the Videha parallel-history perspective, this chapter matters because it grounds linguistic history not simply in governmental recognition but in inscriptions, everyday usage, grammatical writing and the reach of cultural practices. Language crosses political frontiers to become a civilisational continuum.

3.2 Ramanath Jha and the Mithila Language

The longest essay, the backbone of the collection, offers a model of counter-criticism. On the occasion of Acharya Ramanath Jha's birth centenary (1906–2006), it examines the archival record behind the heap of allegations made against him both during his lifetime and after his death. Rare evidence, including Shashinath Chaudhary's council report of 1932, is used to argue that accusations of a conspiracy concerning Maithili's recognition at Patna University are unsupported by fact. The episode of removing Ramanath Jha's half-page "apology" from the fourth edition of Chanda Jha's Mithila Bhāshā Rāmāyaṇa, compared with the Soviet removal of a leader's remains from a mausoleum following accusations of a "cult of personality," is counter-criticism at its sharpest: local literary politics acquire meaning in the light of world history.

The latter part offers a systematic rereading of Ramanath Jha's contributions to teaching, curriculum construction, research, linguistic recognition, editing and literary history. Treating him as a central pillar of Maithili criticism, Raman identifies five kinds of historical evidence for the antiquity of the Mithila language: the dohā in Kalidasa's Vikramorvaśīyam, the metrical forms in Prākṛta Paiṅgala, the Caryāpadas of Siddhas associated with the Sahaja tradition discovered in Nepal, the utterances of Dāk, and Vidyapati's compositions in Avahaṭṭa. The discussion of the sayings attributed to the Buddha and Mahavira and of Ardhamagadhi, the continuity of language in ancient Videha, the distribution of Tirhuta script, Pandit Jivanath Ray's concern for standardisation, and Maharaja Lakshmishwar Singh's historic order of 1880—which permitted Devanagari and Hindi to enter official administration and contributed ultimately to the displacement of Tirhuta

(Mithilakshar)—turn this chapter into a document of language politics. Most original is the reappraisal of Ramanath Jha's work through the four phases of language management associated with Haugen and Ferguson: selection, codification, elaboration of functions and acceptance. Raman demonstrates that Ramanath Jha was already undertaking language planning for Maithili according to the processes of a discipline not yet formally established. The concept of diglossia, the differentiation of linguistic levels in a bilingual setting, successfully brings sociolinguistic analysis to bear on Maithil society's linguistic reality.

In the Indian critical tradition, the critic is termed a sahrdaya, a responsive and discerning reader. In this chapter Raman understands such responsiveness not as uncritical adulation but as historical justice. He insists that a person's contribution must be assessed in relation to the times, institutional constraints and resources within which that person worked. From a reader-response perspective, the chapter illustrates how successive generations judge the same personality differently: what was laboriously established by the founding generation becomes an ordinary convenience for later generations, and the founding struggle is consequently forgotten. At the level of Videha parallel history, the chapter asks how the institutions of Maithili language and literature were built. Universities, curricula, literary organisations and individual scholarship were interconnected. Literary history is therefore not only the history of published texts but also a history of institution-building.

3.3 Kiran as Counter-Critic

This essay confers theoretical standing on the term pratyālocanā—criticism of criticism—in Maithili critical discourse. For Raman, this practice is a sign of society's intellectual mobility and vitality. His threefold analysis of Dr Kanchinath Jha ‘Kiran’ as a popular critic, literary critic and counter-critic, together with his division of writers into three classes—those transcending their age, those following it, and consciously oppositional writers—shows a methodologically alert criticism. He sympathetically presents Kiran's new propositions: that Varṇaratnākara is a work of poetry; that folk literature exceeds elite literature in significance; that Vidyapati was a freedom-seeking combatant; and that the little-known poet Fatur Lal, rather than Chanda Jha, inaugurated the modern age. Yet he also unsparingly exposes contradictions. Kiran sharply repudiates Ramanath Jha's interpretation of Radha and Krishna, but elsewhere calls Vidyapati's heroine an imaginary character shaped by courtly convention and thus, by another route, approaches the same interpretation. In discussing Kulanand Mishra's comments on a lunar eclipse, Raman arrives at something like an ethical maxim for criticism: a

work's ideas must be examined neither with a devotee's submissiveness nor by imposing the critic's own doctrine upon its author.

Kiran raises a critical voice against caste hierarchy, convention, superstition, the devaluation of labour and social inequality. Through Parāśara he confronts questions of labour, hunger, caste division, religious display and relations between women and men, mounting a severe challenge to the pedigree-consciousness and genealogical-register system of an elite scholarly society. From the standpoint of Indian thought, Kiran's criticism is guided by lokamaṅgala, the public good: literary excellence cannot be detached from social responsibility. A Western Marxist reading connects his thought to social production, labour and criticism of the dominant class; from a Dalit perspective he rewrites classical figures in the light of lower-class experience. The concept of the "Maithil eye," placed in opposition to the "enslaved gaze," is an original principle here. It signifies not narrow regionalism but seeing the world through one's own linguistic and cultural experience. In the Videha parallel-history perspective, this restores the dignity of local knowledge and gives voice to subaltern resistance against established elitist historiography.

3.4 Reading Kanyādān through the Eyes of the Neglected Rather Than the Expected

This is among the collection's most challenging chapters, a rare Maithili application of reception aesthetics or reader-response theory. Dividing the readers of Harimohan Jha into three groups—those seeking entertainment, devotees who read as though reciting the Hanuman Chālīsā, and those reading for an understanding of society and narrative —Raman shows that the meaning of a work is shaped by the reader's standpoint. He then proposes a decisive shift of perspective: rather than view the novel through the eyes of the favoured or "expected" figure, an educated groom like C. C. Mishra, read it through the eyes of the neglected Buchchi Dai. This is a feminist method of displacing the centre and making the margins central. Departing from the dominant reading of the novel as comedy, Raman foregrounds Buchchi Dai's silence, lack of education, fear and cultural dislocation. Why does she not speak? Why are decisions about her life made by others? To what extent is educated society responsible for her silence? He attributes Buchchi Dai's illiteracy not to a personal failing but to the "fault of society's structural construction."

The strongest aspect of the argument is the principle that archival evidence must come first. Yashoda in Jansidan's work, who can read the Ramayana; Sumati in Rasbihari Lal Das; Yogamaya in Punyanand Jha; and Mohini in Pulakit Mishra—all female figures from Maithili novels preceding Kanyādān—were literate, not illiterate. This sequence of evidence produces

the provocative conclusion that on the question of women's education Harimohan Jha stands behind, not ahead of, his novelistic predecessors. The comparison between Yoganand in Mithilā Darpaṇa and C. C. Mishra in Kanyādān, and the question "Is the uncomprehending person himself responsible for his incapacity, or is society responsible?" subject comedy to the test of propriety and human dignity. The chapter's subtle linguistic observation is that an urban husband and a rural wife do not inhabit the same cultural and linguistic ground: the husband's choice to speak Hindi deepens the woman's silence. This rereading is exceptionally important for feminist criticism. Behind the humour of marriage lie the objectification of women, linguistic inequality, denial of education and patriarchal control. Buchchi Dai becomes not merely a character but a symbol of the uneducated Maithil girl. In the light of dhvani theory, an undertone of karuṇa, pathos, can be heard beneath the novel's laughter. From the Videha parallel-history perspective, the chapter makes visible again the history of women suppressed within a canonical comic work.

3.5 Lakshmipati Singh, an Unexamined Poet

This chapter is an outstanding example of the seminal method of Videha parallel history: bringing an "unexamined" writer back into the record. By gathering poems scattered across newspapers and journals, Raman reconstructs the poetic world of a forgotten writer and presents him as a poet of national consciousness, attachment to Mithila, social reform, women's suffering, floods, exploitation and cultural crisis. He admits that the complete works are not available, and that this is consequently preliminary research. His interpretation of "Śaradāgama" is a practical application of dhvani theory. In the departing monsoon, flowering kāsa grass, still lake and helpless Purandara, he detects ironic suggestions of the government reforms of 1935 and popular discontent. This discovery of political suggestion beneath the literal description of nature vividly illustrates Anandavardhana's artha-antara-saṅkramita mode of suggestion. In his analysis of the poem "Pachhbā," a symbolic scheme in which the violent gust of Western language and culture blows away the resources of Indian vocabulary seems to anticipate cultural imperialism and connects this essay with the collection's final chapter. "Pachhbā" is not merely a westerly wind but a symbol of Western cultural pressure; autumn's arrival signals a weakening of colonial rule. His gloss on the culturally resonant expression "Not Pūrab," the poignant picture of a widow's lament, and the poet's testimony to the twin catastrophes of flood and earthquake together produce the image of a poet who is "impartial" yet committed to Maithili. From a New Historicist perspective, the poems are not isolated objects of beauty but are read alongside the freedom movement, Partition, social reform, floods and the activities of cultural institutions; karuṇa rasa becomes intense in depictions of widows, flood

victims and a neglected Mithila. Where established literary histories set aside a poet because his books are unavailable, Raman creates an alternative literary biography from works dispersed in the periodical press —a model instance of recovering a forgotten author.

3.6 Yatri's Language: Word Selection and Word Formation

Through four instruments of stylistics—selection, deviation, parallelism and figurative or oblique presentation—this examination of the poetic language of Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' (Nagarjun) becomes the collection's most theoretically equipped and systematically organised linguistic chapter. It demonstrates the creative conjunction of indigenous words, tatsama borrowings, tadbhava forms and other loanwords in Yatri's poetry. Hybrid formations of indigenous and non-indigenous elements such as "aparojak" (for the creator born from the lotus of Vishnu's navel), "ūttuṅg khopā" and "tapovanī," as well as the expressive force of the verb "dalkab," are subjected to close verbal analysis. At each point Raman explains why, among several possible synonyms, one particular word is indispensable: its selection conveys not just denotative meaning but a character's social position, a speaker's mental state, satire and cultural memory. The discussion resembles a modern adaptation of Kuntaka's varieties of phonetic arrangement and of the obliqueness of the first part of the word. The concept of "deviation" is also related to the classical allowance "niraṅkuśāḥ kavayaḥ"—poets are not bound by ordinary restrictions—a rare bridge between Eastern and Western poetics. From the standpoint of vakrokti, departures from grammatical order, unusual combinations and neologisms transform language from an ordinary vehicle of information into poetic experience; under dhvani theory, a word's contextual suggestion matters more than its dictionary definition. The analysis of new contextual meanings for mythological figures such as Gauri, Kartik, Ganesh and Lakshmi, beyond their lexically sanctioned senses; the use of parallelism in the "Skeleton Series" and the "Uncle Song"; and resemblance, personification and sensory imagery in figurative presentation all provide reliable keys to Yatri's distinctive diction. The notion of Yatri's "geography of language" is noteworthy. Knowing the objects, labour, customs, myths and everyday speech of his linguistic world, the poet uses words that are not ornaments but bearers of living communal experience. Yatri's diction also expresses a many-voiced regional world opposed to an elitist, heavily Sanskritised Maithili.

3.7 Unexamined Aspects of Manmohan Jha's Stories

Manmohan Jha is known as a writer of compassion. This short essay's achievement is to disclose two largely unexamined aspects of his fiction: Indian nationalism and a distinctly Maithil subnational identity. Narendra Babu in "Āhata Ātmā," written against the background of the

shooting at the Patna Secretariat in 1942; the story of labourers' suffering concealed beneath the magnificence of the Taj Mahal; "Vīrabhogyā"; Mahashweta in "Saptapadī"; and the sacrifice portrayed in "Mīnākshī" all show that a firm voice of love for the nation and defence of Mithila's culture flows beneath the undercurrent of compassion. From the perspective of rasa, the synthesis of karuṇa and vīra, pathos and heroism, is the stories' essential strength: personal love is transformed into sacrifice for the nation, homeland or cultural identity. Under a New Historicist reading, their emotional worlds are constituted by the independence struggle, foreign invasion and Mithila's cultural memory. In the Videha parallel-history perspective, Mithila is not opposed to the Indian nation but is a distinct cultural unit within it; Maithil subnationalism thus becomes not fragmentation but a layered form of Indianness. Written within ten days of Manmohan Jha's death in 2009, the essay joins tribute and criticism with restraint.

3.8 Migrants' Contribution to the Development of Maithili Journalism

Beginning with a definition of journalism as the impartial dissemination of reading material in accordance with a predetermined purpose, Raman clarifies the distinctions among a periodical, a journalist and journalism. He asks how "journalism" should be understood where a regular, economically self-sustaining newspaper tradition has remained limited in Maithili. Confronting the legal distinction between migrant and resident drawn from foreign-exchange legislation, he argues for the indivisibility of cultural Mithila: the long-unbroken cultural bond between the Nepal Terai and Indian Mithila makes political borders secondary. The journals Maithil-Hitasādhan, published by migrant Maithils in Jaipur in 1905, and Mithilāmod, published in Banaras in 1905, promoted social education, women's education, resistance to orthodoxy, the cultivation of language and a fearless editorial outlook. Their examination, supported by quotations from the journals' introductory declarations, is historically valuable. Particularly subtle is the sociology of knowledge underlying Raman's explanation of editorial independence. Vidyavachaspati Madhusudan Ojha and Mahamahopadhyaya Murlidhar Jha were not dependent on the contemporary centre of power in Darbhanga; they could therefore speak openly. In the terms of public-sphere theory, these periodicals became forums for society's intellectual conversation: questions difficult to raise within Mithila could be voiced boldly in the relatively freer atmosphere of migration. From the Videha parallel-history perspective, migration is not an existence outside Mithila but an extension of its cultural circumference. Jaipur, Banaras, Ajmer, Calcutta, Delhi and Nepal become alternative centres of Maithili consciousness. By proposing that journalism be examined through criteria other than livelihood or

commercial occupation, Raman supplies an alternative, parallel framework for its historiography.

3.9 Dīnābhadrī in Maithili Folk Balladry

This chapter brings textual criticism and subaltern studies into contact. Treating Grierson's 1885 collection of the Dīnābhadrī songs as a primary source, Raman asks why later scholars wrote on the basis of their own collected versions without accounting for variations between those versions and the earlier text. He regards this as a kind of literary disorder: to leave Grierson's collection out of consideration and then declare that the "original ballad remains unpublished" is historically indefensible. His comparative study of the two texts—seven chapters against thirteen, differences in the role of Gulami Jat, and the introduction of English words into Dīnābhadrī's speech after independence—is an authentic demonstration of the principle of flexibility in folk balladry. An orally transmitted ballad changes according to performer, period and audience, and this capacity for change is precisely its source of life.

Dina and Bhadri are heroic brothers from the Musahar community. Their revolt against Zorawar Singh's feudal oppression, courage, brotherly affection, trust in panchayat justice ("justice from the panch"), and resistance to the exploiter show that all the classical qualities of heroism were also present in Dalit society. This is a counter-narrative to a conception of heroism centred on royal lineages. The ballad preserves caste oppression, social inequality, courage, justice and communal memory; the worth of a popular hero is established not by royal office but by defending the oppressed community and safeguarding its self-respect. In Dalit criticism, the chapter is particularly significant: the ballad of a community treated by mainstream history as if it had no history becomes an alternative historical archive in its own right. In the Videha parallel-history perspective, Dina and Bhadri are not heroes of the royal court but heroes of oral tradition. That shift redistributes literary and political visibility, while the suggestion that ballads help create contemporary political space connects the study with present-day debates.

3.10 The Development of the Maithili Story: Some New Facts

This is an excellent example of New Historicist rewriting. Raman challenges the established view that Chanda Jha's translation of Puruṣaparīkṣā (1889) was the point of departure for the Maithili story on three grounds: the improbability that the translation circulated widely enough at the time; the unappealing language of a word-for-word rendering, supported by evidence from Jayakant Mishra and Ramanath Jha; and the implausibility of its supposed influence on scholars already educated in Sanskrit—why would they be inspired by a translation? As an

alternative, he disputes the notion that the history of Maithili narrative begins only with the modern printed story. He treats the art of storytelling, enumerated among the sixty-four arts in Jyotirishwar's Varṇaratnākara; the oral tradition of the third stream of vrata narratives, including Madhushravani and Sirta-Bista; folk tales; humour and satire; and a long tradition of oral narration as the prehistory of modern fiction. The creative achievement here is his distinction between narrative matter and the art of storytelling. What is told is one thing; the language, pace, voice, dialogue and presentation that hold an audience are another. In this view oral literature is not an immature genre but one with an independent aesthetics.

The proposal to take Shrikrishna Thakur's Candraprabhā—composed by the 1880s and published in 1939—as a starting point for the original Maithili story, the correction of the title "Candrabhāgā" to "Candraprabhā," a reconsideration of the genre of "Vilakṣaṇa Dāmpatya," and questions concerning the date of "Madanrāj Carita" are the chapter's research contributions. In his interpretation of the story of King Rasadhwaj in Candraprabhā—a population's non-cooperation and migration in the face of an oppressive ruler—Raman perceives a symbolic expression of popular anger after the failure of 1857. He reads the relationship between rulers and subjects through the figures of a flower garden and its gardener, and discovers in Vidyasindhu's frog story (Indra, Earth and Frog) an allegory of colonial exploitation and satyagrahi resistance. Such readings are felicitous exercises in the reciprocal interpretation of literature and history, a central New Historicist method. In terms of dhvani, the king's tale becomes a criticism of colonial and feudal oppression.

3.11 Mithila's Earthquakes in Maithili Poetry

The essay opens by questioning, at the level of literary theory, why a Maithili poetic tradition rich in descriptions of nature as a stimulus to emotion has so often neglected nature as an agent of destruction. It examines poetic records of the earthquakes of 1934 and 1988. Comparing the poet Sitaram Jha's "Bhūkampa Varṇana" with Krishnanandan Singh's "Kampakārikā," Raman underlines the latter's value as a historical document, including its account of Mithila's political, social and economic condition before the earthquake. It is not merely a description of devastation but a poetic record of contemporary politics, economic life, corruption, prices and reconstruction. His psychological observation on a trauma experienced at eighteen and kept alive in memory for thirty-eight years before being expressed in poetry, the pictures of Darbhanga Hospital and Chaturbhuj Sthan with their mingling of pathos and irony, and the evidence taken from Yatri, Chandrabhanu Singh, Dhirendra and Jivakant

in the 1988 earthquake-poetry anthology together form a miniature history of disaster literature. Dhirendra's perception that humanity becomes one in catastrophe marks the social outcome of karuṇa rasa.

The conjunction of karuṇa and bhayānaka—the pathetic and the terrible—is central to the chapter. Homes, hospitals, temples, markets, palaces and the poor person's hut all fall within the same circumference of destruction; yet the social consequences of an identical natural shock are not equal. Ecocriticism clarifies the difference between a natural event and a socially produced disaster. An earthquake is natural; weak buildings, government neglect, unequal resources and the politics of relief are consequences of human decisions. Within Videha parallel history, catastrophe becomes a legitimate subject of literary history.

3.12 "What Have You Taken Away, Mother Kosi?"

This survey of tendencies in flood literature begins with the anguished outcry of R. C. Prasad Singh and extends through Chanda Jha, Yatri (Kauśikīk Dhār), Lakshmipati Singh, Chandrabhanu Singh, Siyaram Jha 'Saras' and Sukant Som. Kosi and Mithila's other rivers appear in three forms at once: as mothers, as life-giving powers and as agents of destructive flooding. Raman joins the contradiction between the classical prestige of a "river-nourished region" and the realities of annual deluge, hunger, displacement, debt and migration with the folk-song refrain addressed to Mother Kosi. His portrayal of a popular consciousness that interprets disaster as a mother's wrath and seeks to appease her is rich material for cultural studies. Calling Kosi "Mother" creates cultural intimacy, yet the poems also question this mother: devotion and resistance coexist. In Sukant Som's satire on a minister's aerial inspection, the aeroplane flies over figures as gaunt as dried bamboo slats while a smiling green face appears in the newspaper; Raman cites this as a particularly sharp criticism of power. The theft of relief supplies, the coming together of snakes and rats, and environmental damage extend the significance of flood beyond natural catastrophe to political and moral questions. From an ecocritical perspective, the essay crosses anthropocentric boundaries to depict the suffering of birds, egrets, fields, ponds, vegetation and the living environment as a whole. Rivers' natural courses, dams, embankments, systems of relief, official surveys and corruption form a complex political ecology. In Videha parallel history, flood is not an external accident affecting Mithila but a decisive element of its social structure, songs, memory, economy and history of migration.

3.13 The Spirit of the Age in Maithili Epic Poetry

Five epics—Subhadrāharaṇa by Munshi Raghunandan Das, Rādhāviraha by Madhup, Agastyāyanī by Markandeya Pravasi, Tripuṇḍa by Dhirendra

and Parāśara by Kiran—are selected on the basis of five historical concerns: the struggle for independence, women's empowerment, emotional unity within the nation, a young generation committed to labour, and Maithil subnational identity. The method of reading contemporary history through mythological narratives works well as allegorical interpretation: a Subhadrāharaṇa written after receiving a son's letter from prison conveys the tax boycott of the Non-Cooperation movement; Agastyāyanī resolves the language dispute by imagining Tamil and Sanskrit born simultaneously from Shiva's drum; Parāśara proclaims through labour that "food is life," and makes Sita voice Mithila's democratic pride. In accordance with New Historicist theory, mythological characters do not remain imprisoned in ancient time. Arjuna becomes a figure of the freedom fighter's sense of duty; Radha voices women's participation in national life and social reform; Agastya bears the reconciliation of northern and southern India; Shiva becomes a farmer and labourer in Tripuṇḍa; and Parāśara articulates the dignity of work, resistance to caste division, the emptiness of ritual when confronted with hunger, and Maithili identity. The process of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa, or universalisation, in Indian poetics is clear here: particular mythological figures become representatives of modern people's collective aspirations. Careful records of dates of composition and publication also give this chapter credibility as historiography.

3.14 Social Consciousness in the "New Song"

The theoretical contribution of this essay lies in introducing and defining the term na'v gīt, the "new song." It denotes not an age group but an orientation of values: not every song written after the earlier modern song belongs to this new category. The new song moves away from stereotyped inherited subjects, false glory, didacticism and sentimental lament and gives rhythmic form to modern social contradiction, industrialisation, metropolitan suffering, hunger, unemployment and struggle. Treating it as a product of the machine age, Raman defines it by the rhythmic intermingling of intellectual and emotional elements. He draws boundaries between it and four other traditions: the domestic eroticism of older song, Chanda Jha's emotional effusiveness, nostalgic celebrations of a nationalist past, and rhymed verse made for the stage. This is a fine exercise in classification. Intellect and feeling are not enemies within the new song but complement each other; private suffering is universalised into a shared social crisis. Raman's interpretation of Gangesh Gunjan's image of a large tree spreading its leaves over a tiny sprout of dūb grass—as a privileged class overshadowing the new consciousness of the Dalit and oppressed—is a controlled Marxist reading. His analyses of Buddhinath Mishra's early maize crop and Markandeya Pravasi's invocation of Phagun establish the variety of the new song. History written upon sand and a

village burning like a little earthen lamp produce powerful suggestions of contemporary inequality. From a Marxist standpoint, the songs criticise privileged classes, failed development schemes, metropolitan dominance and the punishment inflicted on villages; from a formalist standpoint, they are distinctive in their fresh symbols, fragmented images and rhythms of ordinary speech. The chapter sees the variety of the new song not as weakness but as evidence of living development.

3.15 Current Trends in Maithili Poetry

Read at a symposium in Bhubaneswar in 2012, this paper recalls the shared inheritance of the four sister languages of the eastern Magadhan family—Assamese, Odia, Bengali and Maithili—against the background of India's composite culture. With references to Rabindranath Tagore and Subramania Bharati, Vidyapati's influence and the history of colonial linguistic power, it identifies four currents in contemporary Maithili poetry: concern for the crisis confronting humankind, including Jivakant's farewell to a century ravaged by war; opposition to consumerist culture; resistance to cultural imperialism, including the law of the fish in a unilinear model of development on the information highway; and anxiety over the erosion of biological and cultural diversity, seen in the clearing of six bighas and eight kathas of mango groves and in the departure of egrets. Poems by Jivakant and Uday Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa' illuminate the struggle for human survival and cultural autonomy against the monstrosity of consumerism. In a postcolonial reading, the links among information systems, markets, advanced technology and cultural dominance become visible. This does not mean forbidding contact with external cultures; it means refusing one-sided domination that destroys local language, script, ways of living and imagination. In an ecological reading, the loss of biodiversity, indigenous rice and mango varieties, ponds, egrets and natural habitats becomes a concern of modern poetry. The application of Ashby's law of "requisite variety"—that a system needs at least as much internal variety as exists in the environment it must confront—introduces systems thinking into Maithili criticism and moves the question of survival beyond sentiment to a scientific plane. From the Videha parallel-history perspective, Maithili poetry becomes a poetry of resistance defending the shared linguistic life, indigenous knowledge and cultural plurality of India and Nepal.

3.16 Maithili Folksongs: Their Condition and Preservation

Presented as a response to a conference paper at a national seminar in Janakpurdham, this essay connects the Indian classical basis for honouring folk tradition with the parallel expression "loke ca vede ca," in popular practice as well as in the Veda. Raman begins by criticising the descriptive tendency of the paper under discussion and demands not merely a list of

folksongs but an analysis of their social functions, transformations and causes of disappearance. What will happen to songs accompanying labour once machines replace the grinding stone and mills replace the wooden rice-pounder? The question is highly pertinent. Raman treats folksongs as a collective emotional archive and a repository of traditional knowledge, medicinal experience, agricultural culture, family relationships and rites of passage. The healing properties attributed to fenugreek and turmeric, the social economy of "fenugreek ground by grandmother," the mythic narratives woven into songs of a washerwoman's marital good fortune, and symbols such as basil, bael and bamboo all form part of experiential folk knowledge. The essay is particularly forceful from a feminist perspective: songs preserve evidence of grief at the birth of a daughter, the pre-ultrasound use of pepper in practices relating to the foetus, the devaluation of girls, the exploitation of wives' labour, dowry, control by mothers-in-law and sisters-in-law, and the bodily desires of newly married women. His rasa-sensitive interpretation of the oblique images in lagnī songs—clove blossoms, a net cast into the Yamuna—challenges the artificial separation of elite and folk expression. As preservation measures, Raman proposes using UNESCO's framework for intangible cultural heritage, including three approaches to identification and seven protective steps: archives, museums, classification by region, trained collectors, sound recordings and returning copies to the communities concerned. Drawing also on collective consciousness and Ogburn's account of diversity in cultural elements, he argues that popular cultural power should underpin Nepal's new democracy. The discussion reaches a level of practical policy rarely achieved in Maithili criticism. In Videha parallel history, the folksong is not amusement produced by an "uneducated" community; it is society's living history.

3.17 The New Tactics of Colonialism

The concluding essay marks a practical high point in the collection's postcolonial thought, exposing the persistence of linguistic colonialism after political independence. A detailed examination of Kiswahili in Tanzania—the determination to make it a medium of instruction after independence in 1962, economic crisis, the conditions attached by the World Bank and International Monetary Fund, privatisation, and the restoration of English through British aid programmes—leads Raman to the proposition that, after formal political colonialism has ended, linguistic and cultural colonialism continues through new mechanisms of economic assistance. Parallel instances from Madagascar, Zambia, Malaysia and India, including the case of Karpoori Thakur, strengthen the argument. Equally provocative is his close reading of two visits in Patna on the same day, 19 November 2008: a British minister's visit to a girls' school and a visit by the United States embassy to a women's college. He interprets

these events as a deliberate effort to turn newly developing areas of female education into spheres of influence for colonial languages.

From a postcolonial standpoint, Raman's principal proposition is that the mere withdrawal of colonial rulers does not terminate colonialism. So long as control persists over the language of government, the standards of knowledge, the medium of education and access to employment, colonial power survives in new forms. In India, the growth of private English-medium schools, the educated classes' sense of inferiority towards local languages and the interruption of language transmission within families across generations together create a twofold crisis for Maithili. Fishman's account of language shift supplies a warning: without intergenerational transmission of the mother tongue, language maintenance is impossible; a language no longer passed from one generation to the next faces extinction. Examples of Maithili disappearing as the family language in Maithil households make the essay a warning about "the two-sided assault on Maithili." From the Videha parallel-history perspective, its most affecting element is the rupture of language within the family. When grandparents can no longer speak with their grandchildren, what breaks is not merely a vocabulary but stories, songs, rites, popular knowledge and collective memory.

4. Chapter-by-Chapter Limitations, Contradictions and Incompleteness

Raman himself maintains that criticism is not a letter of congratulation: to refute an expressed view with evidence, or to disagree with it, is not an insult. In literary criticism, offering praise alone is tantamount to fostering factionalism and the narrow confines of a circle of friends. Accordingly, the limitations, class-based exclusions and theoretical incompleteness of each chapter are examined below by precisely the same standard, and with precisely the same respect. These limitations do not diminish the value of the book; rather, they open the way for further inquiry through the principle that understanding arises from continued debate—vāde vāde jāyate.

4.1 The Study of Maithili and the Mithila Language: Limitations

The first limitation lies in the choice of sources. The chapter is founded largely on the testimony of Western scholars—Colebrooke, Beames, Hoernle and Grierson. Indigenous grammatical consciousness before Dinbandhu Jha—the linguistic records of the pañjī registers, the tendency towards lexical compilation in Jyotirishwar's time, and evidence of Maithili usage in the Sanskrit commentarial tradition—remains almost untouched. Consequently, the essay comes to depend upon the very source material of the colonial epistemology it criticises: a familiar self-

contradiction in postcolonial discourse. Second, the contradictions of colonial knowledge production are not analysed sufficiently. Grierson's work was both a means of recognising Maithili and an instrument of colonial census-taking, classification and administration. To view Campbell's vocabulary collection of 1874 merely as an administrative convenience, while failing to recognise the class-discriminatory aspect of Grierson's dialectal divisions—his description of an eastern form as "gāwārī" and of the speech of lower-status groups as the "jolhā dialect"—is to forgo a critique of Orientalist knowledge-gathering that could have illuminated this duality more thoroughly. Third, the principles of functional load and functional transparency are introduced, but there is no domain-by-domain account or comparative evaluation of Maithili in education, administration, commerce, religion and communication. The theory remains at the level of examples drawn from English and Sanskrit; Maithili itself is not measured. Fourth, the question of the social rights of other dialectal forms in defining "standard Maithili"—which structures of power produce a standard—remains unanswered. The causes of the language's decline are concentrated in external assault and administrative neglect; the roles of caste divisions within Maithil society, linguistic indifference among educated groups, the lack of education for women and economic structures receive comparatively little analysis. Fifth, the abundance of untranslated English footnotes excludes readers unable to read English, while the essay closes in a series of questions. Readers are left to assemble for themselves the coherent conclusion to the inquiry into why the writing of a grammar was delayed.

4.2 Ramanath Jha and the Mithila Language: Limitations

The longest chapter in the collection is structurally loose. Counter-criticism, biography, the antiquity of the language, questions of script, standardisation and language planning—the material of six separate essays—have been confined beneath a single heading, blunting the argument at several points. Second, despite the declared commitment to balance, the tone sometimes becomes less a critical assessment of a life and more a defensive tribute. Kiran's objections are called "emotional" and "not well considered," yet the author's own expressions for the opposing side—"kau-carya-pravīṇa," "khidhāṃs" and "laṭuāel-dabakal"—are hardly free from emotion. The neutrality demanded by the counter-critic is sometimes compromised by his own language; without a fair reconstruction of the opposing argument, the reply loses credibility. Third, showing that Ramanath Jha's earlier work accords with the later theories of Haugen and Ferguson is attractive, but carries an equally substantial risk of anachronism. The essay does not examine whether the correspondence reflects deliberate planning or an accidental parallel. Fourth, in the eagerness to establish Maithili's extreme antiquity, some conclusions

concerning the epics, the Buddhist period or ancient territories appear to rest more upon cultural inference than linguistic proof. The antiquity of the name "Mithila" does not by itself establish the uninterrupted existence of the present Maithili language in an unchanged form. Fifth, the chapter is nearly silent on Ramanath Jha's own limitations: the dullness of his word-for-word translations, which the author himself discusses in Chapter 10; the practical failures of his model of standardisation; and the question of whether privileging the speech of elite groups in standardisation devalued the Maithili of other classes and regions. To defend a person and to defend a theory are not identical undertakings; excessive praise risks turning a fully human character into an idealised statue. Sixth, the rebuttal of the allegation concerning the closure of *Sāhitya-Patra* relies more upon argument than on archives. No documents establish the periodical's finances, subscriber numbers or direct reasons for closure.

4.3 Kiran as a Counter-Critic: Limitations

First, the chapter's central proposition—that Kiran's criticism was essentially counter-criticism, rather than arising from independent immersion in literary works—risks serious reductionism. Counter-criticism is reactive by nature, and Kiran's ideas here emerge mainly through the rejection of earlier judgements; his independent aesthetic standards are not reconstructed systematically enough. The question of "reactionism," raised by the author himself, is left without a complete answer. Posing a question and avoiding its resolution is an incomplete discharge of the critic's responsibility. Second, the selection of quotations used to demonstrate contradictions is one-sided. Passages in which Kiran may have corrected or refined his own opinions have not been sought out. Changes of view across forty years of a thinker's writing may indicate development, not merely inconsistency. Third, the episode of Kulanand Mishra and the lunar eclipse is incomplete: Mishra's original argument is not presented in full, and only the portion susceptible to refutation is quoted. Fourth, the insistence upon social justice and *lokamaṅgala*, the welfare of the people, is important; yet measuring literature exclusively by ideological usefulness risks devaluing form, rhythm, complexity, humour, contradiction and artistic freedom. Conversely, confining Kiran's revolutionary class perspective within the framework of traditional figures-of-speech theory may blunt its social edge. The internal dismantling of the *Dūṣaṇa Pañjī* and of the purity codes associated with hereditary rank, towards which Kiran's writings pointed, has not been fully developed. Fifth, the "Maithil eye" is a powerful conception of a local standpoint, but its boundaries remain unclear: does it embrace the experiences of Maithils across caste, gender, class, religion and region, or does a culturally educated, male-centred perspective reassert itself in the name of "all Mithila"? Sixth, the relationship between Kiran's poetic works

—such as *Parāśara*—and his prose criticism, the two aspects of the poet-critic, is not examined. The former is taken up separately in Chapter 13 without a bridge between the two. Moreover, in seeking modern nationalism, class struggle or democratic values in older works, adequate care has not always been taken to preserve historical distance.

4.4 Reading *Kanyādān*: Limitations

The first limitation of this forceful essay is that its succession of questions remains unanswered. "Who is responsible?" is asked repeatedly—illiteracy, parents, relatives, society?—but the author provides no evidenced judgement of his own. The undertaking to read through the eyes of the neglected woman is ultimately suspended in an interrogative posture. Second, the dimension of *hāsya-rasa*, comic sentiment, which underlies the novel's popularity, receives no examination grounded in rasa theory. Is the object of laughter the innocent Buchchi, or the semi-educated society itself? Through what arrangement does a current of pathos flow beneath the humour? How do the narrator's distance and the double meaning of irony operate, and what does the reader's uneasy laughter signify? These questions remain untouched. At several points the rereading turns into a charge sheet, while it is methodologically hazardous to treat every act of a fictional character as direct social reality and then find the author or work morally culpable: *Kanyādān* is a work of humour, satire, irony, exaggeration and the construction of social types. Third, the absence of any discussion of *Dvirāgaman*, in which Harimohan Jha himself composed the sequel, means that the assessment rests upon half the text. Only a reading of the pair of novels together could adequately judge the author's perspective. Fourth, the table of literate female characters in earlier novels supplies quantitative evidence. Without a qualitative comparison of how central their literacy is to those narratives, and how central Buchchi's illiteracy is to hers, the claim of a "step backwards" cannot be considered fully proved. Fifth, the possibility that Buchchi's illiteracy is itself a deliberately fashioned weapon of satire—a mirror held before society—is not addressed. Nor are Buchchi Dai's possible inner consciousness, the resistant meaning of silence, relations among women or the breadth of domestic knowledge fully developed. Sixth, the question of linguistic inequality between husband and wife is valuable, but treating the mere use of Hindi as conclusive evidence of cultural estrangement may be too simple. The combined effects of class, education, the urban–rural divide and unfamiliarity within marriage needed examination.

4.5 Lakshmipati Singh, the Unexamined Poet: Limitations

The author himself admits that from the scattered poems he could gather "only a few." This candid admission is commendable, but it means that conclusions about the poet's impartiality and victimisation by an

intolerant age rest upon a limited sample. Their validity as generalisations remains questionable: exceptional care is required before determining a poet's whole outlook from scattered examples. Second, certain images of nature are treated as straightforward political metaphors. The "western wind" (*Pachhabā*) may indeed symbolise Western culture, and the "coming of autumn" (*Śaradāgama*) may signify colonial decline, but such interpretations require support from the internal structure of the poems, evidence of the circumstances of composition and other poems. Biographical facts and poetic meaning are sometimes conflated; the national atmosphere of a poet's life does not automatically make every nature poem politically suggestive. Third, his prose works—the novels *Śrīcāmuṇḍā* and *Pañcavaṭī*—are merely named. The promise to recover an "unexamined" writer thus stops at his poetry, leaving half his achievement unexamined even after this chapter. Fourth, biographical details, periodical titles and dates abound, while poetics-based analysis of metre, imagery and linguistic register is rare beyond *Śaradāgama* and *Pachhabā*. Lakshmipati Singh consequently emerges as an important thinker, but his individual artistic voice as a poet is less clear. Fifth, the question of how proximity to the courtly-feudal milieu affected his class standpoint is untouched. Alongside opposition to Western culture, what voice did his poetry raise against the exploitation of villagers by landlords? Sixth, no question is raised about the interrelationship of his writings in Hindi and Maithili—the movement of a bilingual poetic consciousness—although this would have connected directly with the discussion of bilingualism in the book's final chapter.

4.6 Yatri's Language: Limitations

First, all four analytical devices are borrowed from Western stylistics, while the proposed connection with Indian poetics—*niraṅkuśāḥ kavayaḥ* and the school of *vakrokti*—remains little more than an indication. A systematic comparison of selection and deviation with Kuntaka's six kinds of obliqueness could have completed the East–West bridge; that opportunity was missed. Second, the examples are drawn chiefly from successful linguistic experiments, and the textual analysis centres mainly on *Patrahīn Nagna Gāchh*. A consideration of Yatri's weaker, excessively artificial, obscure or time-bound coinages, together with systematic inclusion of his later collections and prose, would have produced a more balanced picture of "Yatri's language." Third, deviation is sometimes regarded as proof of beauty in itself, although every violation of grammar is not artistic. Each deviation requires separate evaluation in terms of propriety, context, clarity of meaning and effect upon readers. Fourth, the attractive metaphor of the "geography of language" remains undefined. Without mapping which regions, classes and occupational worlds furnished particular words, and where Yatri obtained them, the metaphor

remains an ornament rather than an analytical instrument. Pride in the indigenous is justified, but languages are always mixed and changing; any rigid separation of indigenous from imported vocabulary is itself historically unstable. Fifth, in the section on parallelism, the lengthy quotation from the uncle-song receives only a brief reading of its social satire—the irony of middle-class life. Stylistic analysis outruns the analysis of meaning. There is also insufficient consideration of sound structure, sentence length, narrative voice, dialogue, satire's multiple levels, linguistic hybridity and variations of language among genres.

4.7 Manmohan Jha: Limitations

This is the shortest chapter in the collection, and its brevity is its principal weakness. An "unexamined aspect" is announced, yet the discussion remains at the level of plot summary: characters are quoted, but there is no analysis of narrative craft—point of view, manner of narration, temporal arrangement, dialogue, narrative pace or the artistic conjunction of compassion and nationalism. The chapter does not distinguish adequately between the words of a character, the narrator's standpoint and the author's ideas. A character's willingness to sacrifice life for the nation or Mithila does not automatically determine the final meaning of the story or the author's position. Nationalism and Maithil subnational identity are generally taken as positive moral values without asking whether nationalism can accommodate caste, class, gender, religious and regional domination. Questions central to disadvantaged groups—hunger and forced labour—are obscured beneath regional pride. In praising self-sacrificing female characters, the critic needed to ask whether a woman's freedom lies in her own choices or in sacrifice for a nation and culture defined by men. From a feminist perspective, glorifying sacrifice may reinforce patriarchal ideals. The relation between the writer's celebrated *karuṇa-rasa* and the newly identified national sensibility is not investigated through rasa theory: does compassion stimulate national consciousness or impede it? Written on the tenth day after the writer's death, the essay allows the tenderness of a tribute to outweigh critical detachment. The customary claim about the influence of Bengali fiction is left untested.

4.8 The Contribution of Migrants: Limitations

First, using the legal criterion provided by foreign-exchange regulation to distinguish migrants from residents is awkward for literary and cultural analysis. The author acknowledges the mismatch but offers no operational definition of his alternative criterion, the "density of cultural Mithila." The argument for excluding the Nepal Terai from the category of migration because of cultural continuity is emotionally compelling; nevertheless, political borders, citizenship, administration, economic

relations and distinct historical experiences must also be considered. Second, the history of migrant journalism remains principally a history of educated male editors and prestigious periodicals. The roles of women editors, printers, distributors, women readers, financial contributors, rural subscribers and correspondents are scarcely visible. Nor does the chapter examine the class position of the editors themselves—the patronage of landed and respectable elites and its ideological consequences. Third, the chapter lacks statistical evidence. How long did each journal survive? What were its circulation, subscriber groups, distribution area, financial sources, regularity of publication, restrictions, governmental pressures and readers' responses? The quantitative foundations expected of a history of journalism are absent; its judgement of a journal's ideological influence rests mainly upon editorial matter. Fourth, the survey of the post-independence period is uneven. *Mithila Darshan* receives attention, but later journalistic undertakings in Delhi, Mumbai and Calcutta barely progress beyond a catalogue of names. Fifth, the shadow side of migration—the idealisation of a homeland from afar, distance from Mithila's lived reality and sentimental nostalgia—is not critically examined. The contribution is celebrated rather than subjected to the kind of critical scrutiny implied by *Hiāol*. Sixth, the boundaries between journalism and the literary magazine become blurred at points. A clearer distinction was required among the functions of literary special issues, social journals, newspapers and journals of opinion.

4.9 Dīnābhadrī: Limitations

First, the author raises but does not himself resolve the central question of textual authenticity: which text should serve as the basis of study? The natural next step—preparing a critical edition with a record of textual variants—is not even proposed. Moreover, the impulse to discover a single original text sits uneasily with the multiplicity of oral tradition. Each region, performer, occasion, caste subgroup and generation makes its own text. Second, Grierson's collection is important, but the mediation exercised by a colonial collector, translator, transcriber and editor is not examined critically enough. How much was altered when a wandering singer's living performance became a written text? This question is essential. Third, the severity with which the claims of Mahendranarayan Ram and Phulo Paswan are rejected as “not in keeping with history” or expressive of a “negative outlook” is not balanced by adequate recognition of their labour in collecting the material. The standards of fair counter-criticism developed in Chapter 3 are somewhat relaxed here. Fourth—and most seriously—the Dalit folk epic is interpreted entirely from an elite critical position. No direct evidence from the Musahar community's own singers, *bhagtās* and living oral tradition is furnished through fieldwork. The Telugu Dalit argument quoted in the chapter—that Dalits themselves

claim the right to speak about Dalit experience—is not brought to bear on the author's own method. The interpretation offered by an external critic may differ from the community's self-interpretation. Nor is the risk of Sanskritising Dīnābhadrī's autonomous, rebellious character questioned when the epic is interpreted within an orthodox framework of liberation from the spirit-world and pilgrimage worship. Fifth, the female figures of the epic—Niraso, Hiriya and Jiriya—receive no independent analysis. Even within a discourse about subaltern groups, women's voices remain marginalised. A more extensive field study was also needed of internal diversity among the Musahars, ritual practices, contexts of performance, economic change and contemporary political uses of the epic.

4.10 The Development of the Short Story: Limitations

First, the dating of *Candraprabhā*—composed, it is suggested, by the 1880s—rests chiefly on the recollection of editor Lakshmipati Singh ("sixty or seventy years earlier") and the description of a tattered manuscript. In the absence of external tests from manuscript studies—the dating of paper, ink and script style—the repositioning of the genre's point of departure is less secure than the essay's tone suggests. Ramdev Jha's erroneous dating of *Madanrāj-Carit* is rejected with a rigour not equally applied to evidence favouring the author's own position: a double standard. Second, self-citation is pervasive. The author himself edited several cited sources, including *Maithilīk Ārambhik Kathā*, *Mithila Darpaṇ* and *Nirdayī Sāsu*. The editorial labour deserves praise, but making one's own edited materials decisive evidence inevitably raises questions of interested judgement; no methodological safeguard, such as independent corroboration, is supplied. Third, the generic character of Jaldhar Jha's *Vilakṣaṇa Dāmpatya*—belletristic prose, a journalistic narrative or a story—is left unresolved. The essay declares it unsuitable for recognition as the first short story but does not formulate the criteria of "story-ness": plot, character and outcome. The boundaries among oral narrative, ritual story, moral tale, *ākhyāyikā*, novel and modern short story are likewise insufficiently defined. Fourth, the possibility of lost material is an important historical question, but moving from "not available" to "it must have existed" is a leap of speculation. External evidence from manuscripts, references, publication advertisements, correspondence and contemporary reviews is needed. The hypothesis of a third, oral stream of narrative also depends upon an earlier assertion by Ramanath Jha, without independent field evidence. Fifth, the conclusion that the translation of *Puruṣaparīkṣā* exerted no influence is possible, but direct evidence of its lack of circulation, readership and impact is also limited. Influence is measured not only by popularity but by linguistic and stylistic imitation. Sixth, the political-symbolic reading of *Candraprabhā* is intriguing, yet not every tale of king and subjects must be an allegory of anti-colonial

resistance. Its possible connections with social didactic tales, the duties of kings and older traditions of instruction needed equally careful investigation.

4.11 Earthquakes: Limitations

The chapter has two centres—Sitaram Jha and Krishnanandan Singh—and its use of the 1988 collection is confined to selected quotations. There is no analysis of the collection's overall tendencies: the number of poets, their varying perspectives or their metrical traditions. Second, although the chapter reads poetry effectively as historical documentation, documentary value overwhelms poetic value. The comparative analysis of metre, sound, movement, pauses, repetition and the structure of *bhayānaka-rasa*, the sentiment of terror, is limited. The question of the propriety of metre for representing disaster—the relationship between pathos and fixed metre—remains untouched. Third, popular memories of earthquakes, preserved in folk songs, proverbs and oral accounts, are entirely missing, although one would naturally expect the author of the chapter on folksongs to employ these sources. A comparison of cultivated poetry with popular expression could have yielded a two-level reading of disaster memory. Fourth, the poet's interpretation of lines from *Kampakārikā*—"the dharmashala survived; the Kashi-Vaidyanath temple survived"—in terms of divine intervention is not examined critically. The contrast between material reasons for the survival of structures and a faith-based reading needed scrutiny. Here the critic remains a reporter of the poet's worldview instead of becoming its analyst; the contradiction between religious belief and the actual distribution of destruction is insufficiently questioned. Fifth, little attempt is made to uncover the distinct experiences of affected women, Dalit settlements, landless workers, people with disabilities and orphaned children. Popular expressions of class and caste discrimination in relief distribution and rehabilitation are neglected. Social inequality can be concealed within the collective suffering of "all Mithila." Comparison of poetic descriptions with historical sources on the causes of earthquakes, geological structures, relief policy, deaths and their social distribution would also have clarified the relationship between literature and history.

4.12 The Kosi: Limitations

This is the most descriptive chapter in the collection: a succession of quotations, poet by poet, with a thin connecting thread of analysis. First, the political economy of flooding is absent: the history of dam building, the Kosi project, Nepal–India water agreements, siltation, changes in the river's course, water management and the permanent displacement of settlements inside embankments. The expression "human-made tragedy" occurs once but is not developed. Flooding thus appears largely as an assault

of fate; criticism of governmental policy is morally forceful but insufficiently precise about policy. Second, prose fiction and novels—*Pañcavaṭī*, *Lilī Rek Paṭākṣep* and *Inkilāb*—are mentioned only by name. The breadth promised by "flood literature" contracts into a discussion of poetry alone. Third, the poignant invocation of the Kosi in folk song, central even to the chapter's title, receives very little textual analysis. The title's promise is not fulfilled by the discussion. Fourth, poems are sometimes read as direct social reports, although poetry also employs hyperbole, symbolism, emotional compression and imagined speakers. Calling the river "Mother" expresses intimacy, but the maternal image may turn natural destruction into destiny or a goddess's wrath, obscuring political responsibility. In many disasters it is not the river but inappropriate dams, weak administration, corrupt relief measures and unequal patterns of settlement that bear responsibility. There is a risk of romanticisation within readings governed by love and pathos. Fifth, the burdens of floods fall differently upon women, lower-caste communities, the landless, livestock keepers and migrant workers; this intersectional analysis needed development. Sixth, the author himself notes the recurrent character of flood poems—much the same experience expressed in much the same manner every year—but does not use that observation to rank or compare the poems according to conventionality and originality.

4.13 The Spirit of the Age in Epic Poetry: Limitations

First, selection of five epics is declared to be purpose-based, but the rationale for exclusion is incomplete. Moving on after observing that "the other epics are not devoid of the spirit of their age" leaves the question of selection bias open. The absence of works such as *Kīcakavadh*, *Dattavatī* and *Citrā* required explanation; merely naming other epics cannot establish whether the selected works adequately represent the tradition as a whole. Second, selecting three prize-winning epics disturbs the book's professed independence from institutions: the shadow of Sahitya Akademi recognition is visible over the choices. Third, in searching for the spirit of the age, the poetic has been subordinated. Almost nothing is said about the realisation of rasa, imagery, the use of metre or the classical characteristics of an epic—division into cantos, type of hero, extensive plot, elevated style, development of character, description and dialogue. The epics are consequently read more as documents conveying ideas than as poetry. Fourth, interpreting mythological characters as modern freedom fighters, social reformers, farmers or regional nationalists can be fruitful, but also incurs the danger of presentism. Ancient myths are not straightforward prototypes of modern ideas. Fifth, the space allotted to individual works is disproportionate: *Subhadrāharaṇa* and *Parāśara* receive far more attention than *Rādhāviraha* and *Tripuṇḍa*. The argument linking *Rādhāviraha* to women's empowerment relies upon two

or three quotations, without examining how this social reading relates to its dominant *vipralambha-śṛṅgāra*, the erotic sentiment of separation. Radha's duty is again defined through service to her husband and nation; her autonomy, body, desire and independent personal life receive limited consideration. Sixth, stopping at a general discourse of "the duty of the age," instead of directly dismantling the caste conflict and elite order implicated in *Agastyāyanī* and *Parāśara*, sacrifices an opportunity for a fuller critique of feudal structures.

4.14 The New Song: Limitations

First, the period and scope of the "new song" (*na'v gīt*) remain obscure. From what date or work does it begin, and which songwriters belong to it? No list or chronology is provided. The definition depends on a sensibility of values, but its standard remains subjective. On this definition many modern poems could automatically become new songs; what specifically makes the form a song is not clarified. Second, the evidence is limited to three or four lyricists—Gunjan, Pravasi and Buddhinath Mishra among them. Drawing a general account of the movement from such a thin sample risks faulty induction. There is no detailed map of the social backgrounds of the new-song writers, their publishing platforms, audiences, generational differences or contributions by women. Third, the distinction between the new song and new poetry is offered in outline, and the reader is sent to the author's own book for further treatment. This self-referential habit leaves an argument unfinished. Fourth, song as song—its singability, vocal design, melodic ascent and descent, sequencing of sound, end-rhyme, measures, repetition, relation to folk tunes and potential for collective performance—is not examined. The phrase "rhythmic intermixture" appears, but without an example of rhythmic analysis. Singability is the very life of the song genre: a social theme alone does not make a composition a song. Fifth, traditional poetry of love, devotion and nature is sometimes dismissed as conventional, although modernity is more than a change of subject. Fresh feeling and transformation within an old subject can themselves be modern. Sixth, there is no consideration of the democratisation of songs through contemporary audiovisual platforms, the internet and electronic magazines. The discussion remains within the bounds of traditionally printed collections.

4.15 Current Trends: Limitations

First, this is the text of a lecture, and its dependence upon its original audience persists in essay form. The long introduction on the kinship of eastern Indian languages, appropriate to the gathering in Bhubaneswar, feels like a digression to the book's reader and reduces the space available for the central subject, "current trends." Second, the four headings used to describe those trends are exceptionally broad: human crisis, consumerism,

cultural imperialism and the environment can cover almost all modern literature. A finer classification based on poetic movements, generations, form, language and aesthetic outlook was needed. Nor does the discussion examine overlaps among the categories: where, for example, do consumerism and cultural imperialism diverge? Third, the density of evidence is uneven. The currents of human crisis and cultural imperialism are well illustrated, but opposition to consumerism rests upon one or two quotations. The number of selected poems is small, and conclusions drawn from them do not fully substantiate a claim to represent all contemporary Maithili poetry. Fourth, the absence of women's and Dalit voices from the list is conspicuous. A critic whose own book has independent chapters on the neglected woman and on Dīnābhadrī creates an internal inconsistency by omitting both currents from the portrait of the present. Feminist, Dalit, Adivasi, migrant, online and formally experimental poetry do not receive adequate treatment as distinct contemporary currents, and the discussion remains largely confined to established poets of the recognised centres. Fifth, the suggestion that Maithili poetry in Nepal followed different tendencies because it "remained different out of fear of the monarchy" is not accompanied by a single example. The proposition is left unsupported. Sixth, the discussion of cultural imperialism sometimes creates a simple opposition between local and external culture. Cultures develop through exchange, mixture, assimilation and resistance: not every external influence is destructive, and not every local tradition is emancipatory.

4.16 Folksongs: Limitations

First, this is not an independent essay but a response to a conference paper, and its structure betrays that origin. It begins by discussing flaws of method in the paper, moves to an independent discussion of folksongs and ends with policy proposals; the transitions among these three parts are loose. Second, the list of seven measures for preservation drawn from the UNESCO framework is largely translated and reiterated. Without field surveys of the specific condition of Maithili folksong—who still sings, which generations, which occasions survive and which are dying—the list becomes a mechanical application. Archives, museums and classification are necessary, but they also risk turning a living folksong into a fixed specimen. Its life resides in singing, occasion, embodied performance, communal participation and a changing text, not simply in an audio collection. Institutional preservation may also blunt the resistant edge of popular expression; that question requires attention. Third, the musical dimension—rāga, tāla and notation—is entirely untouched. The preservation promised in "Condition and Preservation" has been conceived as preservation of text, not of sound or its transcription into musical notation. Fourth, collectors, researchers and institutions receive

recognition, but the questions of ownership, consent, financial benefit, attribution and archive access for the singing communities are not developed sufficiently. Fifth, the patriarchal voice within folksongs—poignant examples of which, including sorrow at the birth of a daughter and *arjal biāni*, appear in the essay itself—is not confronted critically. Enthusiasm for preservation suppresses the question of which parts of the folk inheritance deserve conservation and which require criticism. Sixth, the presence of medicinal or scientific elements in folk knowledge is important, but to treat every inherited belief as scientific truth would be romanticisation. Experiential usefulness must be distinguished from clinical proof. Further analysis was possible of women's humour, collective resistance, authority to create songs and the differences among women's experiences across castes.

4.17 The New Tactics of Colonialism: Limitations

First, the account of Tanzania is extensive, whereas the comparative analysis of Maithili's situation is proportionately brief. The institutional data given for Kiswahili—budget percentages and dates of policy decisions—have no counterparts for Maithili, such as the condition of Maithili-medium instruction in schools or the proliferation of private schools. The illustration is strong but its application is thin. Because differences among the countries' histories, language populations, economies and educational structures are not made sufficiently clear, some comparative conclusions are reached too quickly. Second, the World Bank, International Monetary Fund and foreign aid do play roles in linguistic domination, yet local elites, governmental inaction, parents' concern about employment, educational quality, the shortage of textbooks and the weakness of mother-tongue institutions are also responsible. An explanation centred upon external conspiracy may obscure internal responsibility. A struggle against external linguistic colonialism remains incomplete without examining the internalised sense of linguistic inferiority in Mithila and the operation of internal colonialism; this question is not developed adequately. Third, the essay offers abundant diagnosis but little remedy. The danger of language death is described, but the constructive side of Fishman's own theory of reversing language shift, present in the very work cited, is not brought into the discussion. The reader is alarmed but given no direction. Nor is an absolute opposition between English and Maithili a practical answer. The essay needed to consider an integrated model of multilingual education: foundational learning in the mother tongue, followed by the staged teaching of an Indian link language and an international language. Bilingualism does not in itself extinguish a language; bilingualism marked by unequal prestige creates the crisis. Fourth, the personal examples—a couple who are professors, a lawyer and a rural woman—are supplied without names or contextual references and

cannot be verified. A writer who elsewhere insists upon documentary proof resorts here to anecdotal, almost legendary narration. Fifth, the optimistic claim that entry into the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution in 2003 "breathed life" into the language is not critically tested. In a book published ten years after inclusion, it would have been natural to ask what had changed in everyday language transmission as a result of constitutional recognition. The essay's own argument—that official recognition is insufficient and intergenerational transmission is essential—undercuts this optimism. The concluding self-contradiction remains unresolved. Sixth, too little is said of the prospects for Maithili in urban bilingual households, mixed marriages, among migrant children and through new media.

4.18 Overall Limitations

In addition to the limitations of individual chapters, several weaknesses belong to the book as a whole. First, repetition: a characteristic weakness of essay collections is particularly pronounced here. Kiran's verse beginning "ānāk kānab khasab dekhi kay" appears in two chapters; Sita's declaration that "Janak is not the king's servant" recurs in three; quotations concerning Bholalal Das and points in the Kiran–Ramanath controversy return at several places. Editorial cross-references could have avoided these repetitions. Second, untranslated English: the extensive English quotations in both footnotes and main text deny readers with only Maithili access to the evidence. This is an internal irony of a book committed to the mother tongue. Third, self-citation: a substantial proportion of the sources quoted are works written or edited by the author himself. This testifies to scholarly diligence on one hand, while raising questions about the independence of evidence on the other. Fourth, methodological unevenness: some chapters, such as those on Yatri and Ramanath Jha, are rich in theory; others, such as those on the Kosi and Manmohan Jha, are principally descriptive. Some depend upon close reading, some are documents of historical revision, and others are polemical responses. Diversity enriches the book; without the application of common standards, however, its internal architecture appears uneven and its unifying theoretical argument is difficult to discern. Fifth, printing errors: local inaccuracies and inconsistent citation practices, with some footnotes complete and others incomplete, fall short of the standards of credibility expected of a work so insistent upon proof. Sixth, too few solutions: many of the essays stop at questions and diagnoses. The author has declared question-raising to be an objective in itself; nevertheless, the expectation of a practical programme remains unsatisfied, particularly in the case of language endangerment. Seventh, the author's love of Maithili is the book's source of energy, yet at some points it becomes cultural idealisation, celebration of ancient glory, excessive suspicion of external

forces or overinterpretation of national symbols. Eighth, the book raises questions concerning women, Dalits, labourers and the people at large, but offers relatively little systematic examination of the intersections among these perspectives—the Dalit woman, the landless woman affected by floods, the migrant labourer or the speaker of a borderland language. At points where a complete confrontation with elite dominance was possible, the criticism remains only partially progressive.

5. Overall Critical Judgement

5.1 The Book's Principal Achievement

The most important achievement of *Hiāol* is its interruption of the familiar linear narrative of Maithili literary history. The book asks: who is entitled to call a language independent? Who establishes literary standards? Which writers are honoured in history, and which forgotten? Does material preserved in the people's voices count as literature? Should a woman's silence be read as comedy or social tragedy? Why are Dalit folk heroes excluded from history? Why are earthquakes and floods not events in literary history? What part do centres of migration play in creating Maithili consciousness? How does linguistic subordination survive political independence? Through these questions, the book becomes more than a collection of critical essays: it offers an alternative map of knowledge about Maithili literature.

Viewed through Indian poetics, the book's criticism does not stop at *rasa* and *alaṅkāra*. It connects *dhvani*, *aucitya*, *vakrokti*, *lokamaṅgala* and *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* with social history. From the perspective of Western theory, it raises postcolonial, New Historicist, Marxist, feminist, Dalit, formalist and environmental questions at once, even though the author does not always apply these theories under consistent names or by systematic methods. From the perspective of Videha's parallel-history approach, *Hiāol* writes the histories that run alongside official and prestigious history: histories of linguistic suppression; of neglected critics and poets; of the uneducated woman; of the Dalit folk hero; of migrant journals and newspapers; of oral narrative; of earthquakes and floods; of women's labour and folk knowledge preserved in folksong; and of the breakdown in linguistic transmission between generations.

5.2 Overall Evaluation

The significance of *Hiāol* lies not in providing final answers but in preparing new ground for questions. It is not a complete literary history, yet it is an indispensable guide for future literary history; it is not a definitive theory, but a critical intervention that unsettles the complacency of established theories. The book is at its best when the

writer discovers forgotten documents, demands evidence for accepted conclusions, analyses the subtleties of linguistic form, listens for the voices of women, ordinary people, Dalits and those struck by disaster, and joins literature to living social history. Its limitations become apparent when polemic outweighs analysis, inference replaces proof, national or cultural faith suppresses aesthetic scrutiny, and complex history is reduced to simple oppositions. Moreover, where a complete confrontation with elite dominance was possible, the criticism sometimes remains only partially progressive. The dismantling of hereditary rank, the pañjī institution and state-sponsored establishments is less incisive than might have been expected.

6. Conclusion

Taken as a whole, *Hiāol* belongs to that rare category of Maithili critical works which subject both reverence and doubt to the test of evidence. From the standpoint of Indian poetics, its fundamental standard is *aucitya*, appropriateness: the appropriateness of words in the chapter on Yatri, of the reader's standpoint in the chapter on *Kanyādān*, and of historical narration in the chapter on the development of the story. *Dhvani* theory is brought into practice in readings of *Śaradāgama* and *Pachhabā*, and an awareness of *rasa* is present in the chapters dominated by compassion, although detailed rasa analysis remains one of the book's weaker aspects. By Western standards, it is a pioneering Maithili application of postcolonial and sociolinguistic discourse, limited by its unequal, and occasionally mechanical, use of theory. From the standpoint of Videha's parallel history, its importance is paramount: the unexamined poet, the neglected heroine, the Dalit champion, the migrant editor and the unknown singer of folksongs—figures relegated to the margins by institutions—are brought to the centre by Raman through the force of documentary records.

Yet even from this perspective one final boundary should be drawn. The full method of the parallel tradition is realised where marginalised voices speak for themselves. In *Hiāol*, others speak on behalf of the margins more often than the marginalised are enabled to speak. This incompleteness invites future research. Precisely this capacity to invite further debate—to bring thinkers before an ongoing critical conversation—constitutes the book's lasting value. In the history of Maithili criticism, *Hiāol* will be remembered both as a model work of counter-criticism and as a preparation for parallel historiography.

Dr Ramanand Jha "Raman"'s *Hiāol* (2012) is a commendable and courageous advance in Maithili literary criticism, offering serious intellectual challenges to numerous established positions. Raman's love of the language and devotion to its distinctively Maithili vocabulary and

cultural expression are wholly admirable. Despite the theoretical limitations considered here, *Hiāol* remains a major milestone along the long road of Maithili critical theory, offering future generations guidance for confronting established elite historiography with *hiāo*—courage. Beyond literature's front entrance, the book offers a way of seeing history through the back door, the courtyard, the field, the river, the people's voices, women's silences, the Musahar epic, the migrant's periodical and the home collapsed by an earthquake. In this sense it is a powerful foundational work for the critical approach of Videha's parallel history.

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12. Kedarnath Chaudhary's Novels "Chameli Rani" and "Mahur"

Abstract

Kedarnath Chaudhary's first novel, Chameli Rani, appeared in 2004. The novel ended so compellingly that readers demanded a sequel, and the author had to write its second part, Mahur. Reviewing Chameli Rani in Vidyapati Times, Dhirendranath Mishra had written: "...just as the emperor of humour, Harimohan Babu, had to write Dviragaman after Kanyadan, the novelist too will have to write a second part to Chameli Rani."

Keywords: Kedarnath · Chaudhary · novel · Chameli Rani · Mahur · theory of criticism · Maithili

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remained in office despite disappearing, because of precisely such political constraints; no one could remove him, however much difficulty the administration of the state encountered.

The novelist's experience of life had enabled him to write down the possibility of such an event four years earlier. The ability to foretell the future is not acquired through sorcery or incantation: lived experience makes such anticipation possible.

The characters in both novels are remarkable, and convincing as well, because the novelist has created them as though he had personal experience of everything they undergo.

At the opening of Chameli Rani, the author passes his first test: the rhythmic beginning immediately arouses the reader's interest. Kirttimukh's intimate friend Kantir offers this advice on naming his five sons: "Give the five boys the names of the five Pandavas. It will be convenient." Elsewhere, the author observes that, had children continued to arrive at the same rate, names from the Kauravas would have been required. Until the heroine Chameli Rani appears, the narrative describes Kirttimukh's sons, followed in turn by the offspring of the Englishman Demsford and Rupkummari, their daughter Sunayana. Then comes the marriage of Shanichari—daughter of Sunayana, herself Rupkummari's daughter—to the political leader Ramthenga Singh "Chingari"; the leader leaves Shanichari with Kanhi Modiyain out of concern for public shame and goes to Patna. The account of his death, and of Shanichari's subsequent marriage to Kirttimukh, draws the narrative threads together again.

Chameli Rani is introduced next. She studies as a boarder at the school attached to the Barauni Refinery and is the daughter of Kanhi Modiyain. By the time Kanhi Modiyain dies, Chameli Rani has passed the tenth-standard examination. Bhukhan Singh is Chameli Rani's adoptive father. The first part of the novel ends with an account of a robbery.

In the second part, the planned looting of an MLA's money or treasure is depicted as though it were the consequence of a rape committed against a modern young woman by MLA Nangatnath. This Nangatnath had been a personal attendant of Chief Minister Gulab Misir and had contrived, through political manoeuvring, to become an MLA.

This character closely resembles Balram Halwai in Aravind Adiga's English novel The White Tiger, which won the Booker Prize in 2008. Balram works at a tea shop, becomes the driver of a wealthy man in Delhi, murders him and makes himself rich. Yet Chaudhary had created his character four years earlier. Next comes the KGB agent Bhataji, whose

presence continues to exert a powerful influence right through to the novel's second volume, Mahur.

The third part of the novel presents an engaging account of Ahmadullah Khan's campaign and embraces the ugliness of contemporary politics. The fourth part tells Gulab Misir's story, again recalling Adiga's Balram Halwai. Gulab Misir summons Panna, a companion of Bhukhan Singh, and tells him about Bhukhan Singh's involvement in the Nangatnath and Ahmadullah campaigns. He also orders Panna to kill Bhukhan Singh, but Panna refuses. Gulab Misir nevertheless has Bhukhan Singh murdered through deceit.

The fifth part discusses Bhukhan Singh's trust. Chameli Rani abandons her base and moves to Baidyanath Dham. Her political ambitions now come into view. A sting operation takes place, and Gulab Misir finds himself cornered.

The sixth part speaks of the formation of merely a fact-finding committee even after the chief minister has disappeared—an observation on the compulsions of coalition politics.

The opening part of the novel's second volume, Mahur, similarly winds its way around the organisation of Chameli Rani's political party. The author chooses organisations associated with violence against women, the plight of child widows and the forcing of women into prostitution as subjects for his commentary.

The second part of Mahur recounts Gulab Misir's arrival in the capital. Chameli Rani visits the base of a Naxalite leader to secure support for her campaign. This provides the occasion for the author's view of the Naxalite movement as a whole, while his vivid, pictorial rendering of forest life and the lives of Adivasi people bears witness to his narrative skill. Another revelation comes to Chameli Rani: her mother, Kanhi Modiyain, had belonged to a very prominent family; Patel had subjected her to atrocities, Chameli Rani's father had been murdered, and her unfortunate mother had lived out her life under the identity of Kanhi Modiyain. These disclosures lend further fascination to the narrative.

The third part of Mahur once again generates mystery and suspense through the conspiracies involving Pachkauri Mian, Gulab Misir, the ISI and the KGB.

The fourth part of Mahur describes Chameli Rani's revenge for the atrocities inflicted on her parents. She becomes wealthy after acquiring property worth several thousand crores.

The fifth part of Mahur ends with political manoeuvres and the electoral victory of Chameli Rani's party.

Critical Discussion: Despite the bourgeois origins of the novel, the form contains such complexity that it provides a severe test of literary talent. Although Cervantes's Don Quixote appeared at the beginning of the seventeenth century, it was only shortly before the arrival of the nineteenth century that the novel, notwithstanding its bourgeois beginnings, acquired a fully serious form. In the novel, debate and dialogue generate the essay; the presence of young men and women produces a romance; people and geography provide historical description; and then stories of good and bad characters emerge. At times the novel makes readers laugh, at other times it instructs them. Marxism advocates the social reality of the novel. Freud regards every human being as mysterious. Where he takes a literary work as an occasion for analysing its creator, neo-Freudianism appears to emphasise cultural rather than biological elements. New Criticism is based on close and detailed attention to the work. Alongside all these approaches, lived experience constitutes another dimension. Here, to gratify repressed desires, the author has created a world in which the reader walks the narrow boundary between reality and imagination.

Supplementary Discussion

Kedarnath Chaudhary's first novel, Chameli Rani, appeared in 2004. The novel ended so compellingly that readers demanded a sequel, and the author had to write its second part, Mahur. Reviewing Chameli Rani in Vidyapati Times, Dhirendranath Mishra had written: "...just as the emperor of humour, Harimohan Babu, had to write Dviragaman after Kanyadan, the novelist too will have to write a second part to Chameli Rani." These two volumes will be remembered in the history of Maithili novel-writing for several reasons. To begin with, as Ramlochan Thakur asks, "...why has this writer of touchstone-like talent made his appearance so late?" The question genuinely remains unanswered. The author devoted his energies to study and employment in America, Iran and other places; but when the producer of Mamata Gabai Git returned to Darbhanga, he poured the entirety of his life experience into these two novels. I once asked Rajmohan Jha about this in an interview, and he said that creative writing was impossible without lived experience: the broader an author's experience of life, the greater the variety and novelty that author could introduce. Kedarnath Chaudhary's Chameli Rani and Mahur demonstrate the truth of this observation. Chameli Rani established a new sales record: five hundred copies were sold in Janakpur alone. The author dedicated Chameli Rani "to every lover of Maithili who, at some point in an entire lifetime, has spent even a coin of their own money on a book or periodical in the Maithili language." Yet such was its extraordinary sale that a second

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13. A Review of Subhashchandra Yadav's Short-Story Collection "Banait Bigadait"

Abstract

In most of the stories in Subhashchandra Yadav's collection Banait Bigadait, one finds that the narrative moves forward with a theme rather than a mere anecdote, and comes to an end as soon as its task is accomplished. The language of Balchanma is the autobiographical language of that novel's central character; here, however, the language belongs to the storyteller himself, and for this reason assumes a distinctive form. Subhash's preference for taking a theme through a sharply delimited space, against the tradition of turning the short story into a didactic tale, together with his attention to a thoroughly indigenous linguistic craft, will afford boundless pleasure to one group of readers. At the same time, the collection will not disappoint readers who have yet to move beyond the traditional tale; instead, it will refine their tastes.

Keywords: Banait · Bigadait · Subhashchandra · Yadav · short-story collection · theory of criticism · Maithili

In most of the stories in Subhashchandra Yadav's collection Banait Bigadait, one finds that the narrative moves forward with a theme rather than a mere anecdote, and comes to an end as soon as its task is accomplished. Its language is another distinguishing feature. The language of Balchanma is the autobiographical language of that novel's central character; here, however, the language belongs to the storyteller himself, and for this reason assumes a distinctive form. Subhash's preference for taking a theme through a sharply delimited space, against the tradition of turning the short story into a didactic tale, together with his attention to a thoroughly indigenous linguistic craft, will afford boundless pleasure to one group of readers. At the same time, the collection will not disappoint readers who have yet to move beyond the traditional tale; instead, it will refine their tastes.

Some questions of linguistic standardisation deserve attention—for example, the forms ऐछ, अछि and अ इ छ. At the time when standardisation was taking place, these matters needed to be considered. If, for instance, we write "जाति रही" instead of "जाइत रही", we must then devise a pronunciation rule for the word जाति understood as जा-इ-त; the relationship between ऐछ and अछि is of much the same kind. But the opportunity has now largely passed. The author himself offers some direction by adopting a form in "Kaniyan-Putara", only to revert to the other forms in subsequent stories. Even so, this demonstrates the need to

establish a standard form. Whether one chooses to write "छै" or "छैक", either is acceptable, provided that, in the latter case, a pronunciation rule specifies that the final क is silent. Such rules must be formulated promptly and accepted generally. People today do not have a lifetime to spend arguing about whether to write "य" or "ए". Follow phonetic principles; otherwise, prescribe clear rules of pronunciation. Writing "नञि" for "नहि" is intelligible, but among नइँ (Antika), नइं (NBT) and नँइ (Saketananda's Kalaratrishcha Daruna), Saketananda's usage accords more closely with the principles of phonetics. Anyone unconvinced should seek the assistance of a phonetics laboratory. (Audio files illustrating a scientific, standard Maithili alphabet are available for listening or download through the Videha Audio link in the Videha Archive at http://www.videha.co.in/.)

A particular merit of Banait Bigadait is that Subhashchandra Yadav employs a distinctive, phonetically sensitive style of writing capable of advancing the dialogue about standardisation.

The journey of the story encompasses Vedic narratives, Jataka tales, Aesop's Fables, the Panchatantra and the Hitopadesha, together with folk ballads that have continued alongside them. Everywhere, the narratives of the elite have coexisted with those of the folk tradition.

The likelihood of failure is greater in a short story than in a novel, an epic or a long narrative, for the novel resembles a "soap opera" that continues for months or years, with each episode reaching a stopping point. Thus, in a seventy-episode novel, a reader may retain hope through the sixty-ninth episode that the story will take a new turn. If its direction never changes by the end, all the preceding episodes may still be hits and only the final episode a failure. The short story permits no such latitude. It is a work consisting of one episode: either it succeeds magnificently or it fails outright.

Moving beyond the history of traditional tales, the modern short story emerged towards the end of the nineteenth century. It came to be classified as the very short story, the short story and the literary tale, although the distinctions among these three were often explained with needless elaboration. The movement beginning with Rabindranath Tagore spread from one end of India to the other as part of a reformist impulse. Writers such as Bezbarua in Assamese, Fakir Mohan Senapati in Odia, Apparao in Telugu and Kedarnath Banerjee in Bengali spoke at times in support of women and at others against the moneylenders who exploited society. In Nepali, Suryakant Gyawali wrote "Devi Ko Bali" in opposition to the custom of animal sacrifice at Dussehra. Some stories challenged the barriers of caste and wealth placed in the way of love; others dealt with the

condition of Dalit society or with religious superstition. Nor did such stories invariably end happily.

Ideologies and Literature: Postmodernist, existentialist and humanist positions are all schools of thought within philosophy. In earlier times philosophy encompassed science, history, society and politics, economics, the arts and language. But as branches of science and art—especially science—acquired their own specialised forms, the domain of mathematics and science within philosophy became largely restricted to mathematical logic. Philosophers increasingly turned to the study of induction and deduction and to analytical methods. Marx, who seemed almost like a divine intervention to the poor throughout the world, made the dialectical method the foundation of his interpretation. What is now called "discussion" or dialectic, containing both a position and its opposition, had already existed in philosophy's methods of refutation and defence, particularly in the six systems of Indian philosophy (see Madhavacharya's Sarvadarshanasangraha).

Francis Fukuyama, who had proclaimed the end of history after the collapse of communist rule, subsequently retreated from that assertion. Postmodernism, too, has faltered after its initial enthusiasm. Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, Romanticism and sociological analysis have preserved their place by becoming part of a synthetic method of criticism.

Because psychoanalysis rests on a scientific foundation, it will continue to maintain its existence, as the dialectical method has done.

What is the modern short story? What ought it to be like? Does it have a purpose, or ought it to have one? And how should that purpose be determined?

Psychology, too, may provide the basis of a story. The purpose of storytelling should correspond to society's needs; changes in the course of storytelling should reflect changes that have taken place, and are taking place, in society. Yet a story is also governed, almost of itself, by the culture of that society. In it, the society's historical existence comes into view.

When we speak of Vedic narratives, they bring love of the nation to the fore and teach people how to live together in society.

The Jataka tales seek to propagate Buddhism along with the spread of the languages of ordinary people.

A narrative of the Muslim world, such as Rumi's Masnavi, is a distinctive work of Persian literature that teaches the importance of knowledge and the advancement of the state.

Contemporary storytelling embraces all these elements and moves towards the creation of an enlightened and humane (!) society. If it does not do so, this aspiration ought to become part of its purpose. Only then can the analysis and criticism of stories become an imperative for readers.

After the end of communist rule and the fall of the Berlin Wall, Francis Fukuyama declared that history, created by the conflict among ideologies, had reached its end and that henceforth only an ideology serving human welfare would advance. Not long ago, however, he withdrew from this position, observing that many different ideologies still survived within societies and among nationalities. Similarly, the postmodern thinker Jacques Derrida, by deconstructing language, showed that its separated elements depend on many different foundations and that we cannot arrive at linguistic meaning without understanding those foundations.

Like psychoanalysis and the dialectical method, the analyses of Fukuyama and Derrida will, through synthesis, endure as lasting models of criticism.

Subhash Chandra Yadav's Short-Story Collection Banait Bigadait:

Subhash belongs to the generation of storytellers who came after Independence. He gives form to life through the story, rendering it meaningful by enriching both its craft and its subject matter. It is only natural, then, that his stories should depict the struggle of ordinary people for existence. In his story "Kathak Banal Lok", written several decades ago, perhaps it was only by chance that Badariya went on smiling. The characters in this collection possess similarly distinctive qualities. A character who has fallen asleep while weeping in a hospital wakes and begins to cry again; another is in love. Some possess business sense; others resemble Harivansh, whose attempts to help someone result instead in harm because of faults in the system. Let us now examine the stories in Banait Bigadait more closely.

"Kaniyan-Putara": In this story, a little girl in the street stretches herself across the narrator's feet and rests her head against his knee without apprehension, as though she were resting against her mother's knee. Something firm, like a lemon, presses against him: it is the girl's chest. She remains entirely unselfconscious, as if leaning against a father, grandfather, brother or sister. The narrator wonders whether she will become Sita or Draupadi. The spectres of Ravana and Duryodhana close around his thoughts.

After reading "Kaniyan-Putara," the same crossroads remains, and the same boys and girls are visible when one starts or stops a car at the traffic light. But the gaze has changed. These are children who wipe car windscreens and ask for money; whether one gives them anything or not, one had previously driven on without another thought. Can that gaze

remain unchanged after reading "Kaniyan-Putara"? A boy may grow up to steal, or become the lowest rung in some drug cartel. But the girl? Will she become Sita, Draupadi, or Amrapali? Social organisations and human-rights organisations, which spread a net beneath a lover threatening to jump from an electricity pole and use the television cameras to publicise their own names and those of their institutions—can they continue to operate with their old outlook after reading this story? And a government that considers its duty discharged by renaming a hospital after Jayaprakash Narayan or Hardinge Park after Veer Kunwar Singh: will it reach the roots of the problem and build a new hospital and a new park in those names, or simply stamp "Made by Me" on someone else's work? Will these institutions not finally put an end to their tendency to avoid sustained effort and look for easy solutions?

"Asurakshit" ("Unsafe"): This story vividly describes how dangerous the twenty-minute walk home from the railway station has become after dark. It was not like this before—or so people's mental picture of the past would have it. Yet who pays attention to problems of this kind? The media attend to grand questions, economic liberalisation and countless other subjects. Here a new perspective falls on the everyday insecurity of crossroads and public squares: between station and home, a short distance rises like a mountain in the darkness. The story is, in this sense, a comment on the prevailing condition of law and order in the state.

"Ekaki" ("Alone"): Kusesar is in hospital. The hospital is described with vivid detail. A woman there, after the death of her husband, seems to fall asleep from crying; when she wakes, she begins to weep again. Such things happen. The storyteller points towards a truth of human life and comments on the hospital's arrangements, not by delivering an abstract statement but by making the situation live before us.

"O Larki" ("That Girl"): Against the background of life among young men and women in a hostel, a young man named Naveen sees a girl holding two crumpled, empty cups, belonging to her and her lover. She asks Naveen where he is going. He imagines that she has taken him for someone beneath her and is asking him to throw away the cups. He refuses. The thought continues to revolve in his mind. The story turns on a small incident: did she ask him to dispose of the tea cups because she considered him inferior? Naveen says no firmly and walks on. Like "Ekaki," this story is founded on psychological analysis.

"Ekta Prem Katha" ("A Love Story"): In the days when only a few households had a telephone, calls frequently came to one house for someone living elsewhere: "Please go and call so-and-so." The narrator had a telephone at home and would summon a young man whenever his girlfriend rang. After the young man bought a mobile phone, those calls

stopped. But when he changed his number, the girlfriend again began calling the narrator's house. The woman is Ritu, a friend of the young man's maternal cousin, and the narrator becomes anxious to help her. Lovers, mobile telephones and telephone calls enter this new story naturally, as elements of a changing age.

The title story is "Banait Bigadait" ("Making and Unmaking"). It has three named characters: Mala, her husband Satto, and their granddaughter Muniya. The familiar quarrels of a village household between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law have dwindled into such gestures as occasionally asking, after a bath, whether someone has eaten. Yet when that same son and daughter-in-law leave home, the mother-in-law grows anxious even at the cawing of a black crow. The story depicts the reality of the village after migration. One day the crow, too, will disappear along with Satto, and Muniya will search for both the crow and her grandfather. It is a migrant's story, a story of son, daughter-in-law and granddaughter—and of the quarrels and affection between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law.

In "Apan-Apan Dukh" ("Each One's Sorrow"), a wife who feels neglected curses her children. At night the children eat, and after they have finished the kitchen is locked; the wife remains hungry, and her irritation at her husband's snoring is a natural consequence. Everyone inhabits a world of their own. People imagine that the joys and sorrows of their particular world constitute the whole of life, but this is not so. Everyone has their own happiness and suffering, hopes and aspirations. The storyteller discloses truths that fall within the scope of his experience. How can subjective experience be independent of its surroundings? This question comes to the fore throughout Subhashchandra Yadav's stories.

In "Atank" ("Terror"), the storyteller meets an old acquaintance, Harivansh, at an office. The narrator's application for mutation of a land record has gone unattended because, after Harivansh's transfer, no one took a bribe from him—and so no one did the work. Harivansh's flourishing garden was the product of surplus money from bribes; why would someone else surrender an opportunity to earn? The narrator feels terrorised. The office atmosphere, corruption, and the change in social relations brought about by one man's transfer are all expressed here. Nowadays, when either you or I go to the block office or secretariat on some errand, are we not told the same thing: pay whatever is demanded, and if there is still a problem, then come and tell us! If you arrive instead with someone's name or a recommendation, the official will neither take your money nor complete your work.

In "Ekta Ant" ("An Ending"), the narrator's brother-in-law has had his head shaved after the death of their father-in-law, whereas the narrator has not; this provokes all manner of remarks. Having shaved his head, the

brother-in-law is at peace. Cultural symbolism emerges here: the one who is caught is declared a thief and wrongdoer, while the one who escapes detection is counted an idealist. Not entirely, but in this story too, such a belief arises and is then broken. In Haryana, people do not shave their heads even when their own father dies: does that make their grief any less? Women in Punjab neither apply sindoor nor wear bangles after the first year, but during that first year their arms are covered with bangles up to the shoulders. Does their love for their husbands diminish after the first year of marriage?

In "Kabachu," the man who gives massages approaches the narrator and lays a hand on his thigh. Because the narrator is seated among people of genteel, upper-class manners, he moves the hand away. The masseur asks what reluctance there can be in touching a body that has already been touched—as though he imagines that the narrator has mistaken him for a young woman. The narrator begins to feel that he himself is a woman and the masseur an old male companion. The masseur lacks a fine sense of appropriate place and time; otherwise the narrator might have accepted a massage even in such intense heat. He feels pity for the masseur's poverty, yet also revulsion when he recalls the man's drawn-out "sh-ee-ee." Freud's psychoanalysis has been much criticised for placing sex at the centre of its arguments. Experience, however, brings out this point: the more one distances oneself from sex, and the more one keeps it outside conversation, fiction and literature, the more violent its intrusion becomes.

In "Karbar" ("Business"), the narrator meets Mr Varma, Sinha and two other men. At a bar, Sinha distinguishes friendship from business by telling two stories. The first concerns the proposition that everything has a price: after a man buys a television for a friend's wife, she demands a refrigerator; the story is left unfinished. In the second, a woman goes to a former lover to obtain money for a doctor's fee that could save her husband's life. In return for the money, the former lover asks her to spend the night with him. Sinha assigns no blame to anyone in this story. Why should the doctor provide treatment without payment? Why should the former lover give away money for nothing? And if the woman refuses to spend the night with her former lover, her husband will die.

As the narrator leaves the bar, even the doorman's salute begins to sound to him like the clink of money. The disintegration of older values, friendships and ideals produces an experience of loneliness.

Freud also comes to the fore in "Kushti" ("Wrestling"). The story begins with a hard, dried stain on a lungi, but it soon becomes clear that this is not the stain first suggested; it is the mark of a wound. The narrative then moves to wrestling at the market, where village problems are resolved, and to talk of the health centre being closed and bricks having been stolen

from it. There is also discussion of a younger brother who, during the course of treatment, has come to prefer homeopathy to allopathy. People visit to inquire about the narrator's wound. He gives many of them a full account, but brushes aside several who are younger than he is. These linked incidents create the story's atmosphere.

The characters in "Canary Island's Laurel" are Subhash and Upiya. The story offers an image of a decision resembling the collapsing banks of the Kosi. A letter arrives from a maternal cousin; there is a boat crossing by the manoeuvre called katāri dene, passage into a current of ochre-coloured water, and disembarkation on a sandy shoal, beyond which thigh-deep water stretches for a long distance. Seeing someone push a bicycle across the burning sand, a passer-by calls out: "Did they give you that bicycle at your in-laws' house? Give it a little cattle-driver's shout, like an ox!" Subhash hears his elder sister and brother-in-law speak of how their daughter's wedding was delayed by two days for the sake of a coat, and of the notion that excessive education drives people mad. Though he wishes to, Subhash cannot bring himself to ask for two hundred rupees. His sister's conduct remains ambiguous, and Subhash, unconvinced and uneasy, returns home.

In "Trishna" ("Longing"), the narrator meets Akhilan, who tells him about an encounter with Shrilata. When he returns on the fifth day, he does not find her on the train. What will Akhilan do now—keep travelling between Visakhapatnam and Vijayawada, or spend his days in the company of memory?

"Canary Island's Laurel" and "Trishna" offer analyses of small, emotionally charged incidents.

In "Dana" ("A Grain"), Mohan has gone for an interview. A sympathetic office attendant informs him that outsiders are not recruited there; if he had a PhD, matters might be different. Everything appears sick and dejected to Mohan. A little bird and a myna dart, chirping, at a fragment of bread. The story gives a sensitive account of the distinction between "local" and "outsider" as it operates in interviews for competitive recruitment.

In "Drishti" ("Vision"), a man finishes his studies and searches for employment, enduring the sharp taunts of villagers. Eventually, inspired by a journalist from South India, the narrator takes up farming in his village despite his wife's opposition. Ordinary as these events may sound, they disclose social truths at several points. There is village gossip and intrigue, arising from the abundance of unoccupied time when work is scarce. Alongside this is the aspiration of contemporary women to lead an urban life.

In "Nadi" ("River"), the subject develops with the narrative and ends with it. Bihari arrives at Gagandev's home. He must stay in the city for a year. While helping him look for accommodation, Gagandev encounters a girl. Even after leaving her and moving on, knowing that he will never meet her again, he finds himself filled with a feeling of delight and love.

"Pralay" ("Deluge") is a flood story, set amid the waters of the Kosi. Bauki is waiting for Bunchek, but the water is rising in the channel. The Kosi flood advances, while Bauki is already exhausted by the demands and reproaches of his mother. The cattle cry out with hunger. Since Ramcharan has more food and supplies at home, he asks the others to arrange a boat. Kataniya lies far from Bauku's home. Death and destruction have hardened Bauku and broken the ties of attachment. But then the rain stops. Bauku begins trying to recognise things and call them back to memory.

In "Bat" ("A Matter"), too, the storyteller finds his plot while walking along the road and develops it through craft. At a lemon seller's stall, the narrator hears an argument between the vendor and another man and intervenes. Someone is demanding the umbrella he had put down beneath the stall. According to the narrator, people remember sorrow for a long time.

"Rambha" describes the changing relationship between men and women at a rapid pace. So long as a man remains distant from women, each appears to him a Menaka or Rambha; but when conversation begins, the narrator eventually feels that the woman is like his own daughter. A woman approaches along the road. Who is she, he wonders—Rambha, Menaka, or someone else? She has a son, who is not particularly handsome, and he concludes that the boy's father cannot be handsome either. During their conversation the woman sometimes treats the narrator like a father-in-law, and at other times compares herself to his daughter. At first the narrator dislikes this; later it pleases him. Yet at the end, when she bends to touch his feet but straightens up without touching them, he cannot understand her gesture.

"Hamar Gam" ("My Village") describes the road to the narrator's village, the dispersal of people from Kataniya towards the village of Menahi, and those picking their way between embankments. The people of the Kosi region live in conditions scarcely distinguishable from those of animals. The narrator's house at Kataniya was swept away, and he is therefore staying with Nathuniya. Nathuni makes arrangements for fishing and catching birds. There is a dispute over land: a co-sharer, whose own holding has sunk into the river, wishes to appropriate the narrator's wheat field. People are driven to distraction over land and women (!).

The author has begun pursuing women without adequate reason, much as Vishnu Sharma, while telling the stories of the Panchatantra, repeatedly turns against Shudras and women.

While everyone keeps drinking tea beside Kamal's fire because there are no cups available, the harvest is cut and carried away to Sibanan's place. When the forests of jhau, kans grass and reeds were still standing, birds came in great numbers; now there are fewer. Wild animals, deer, fish, turtles and dokas are disappearing: the resources that sustain life have become scarce. In the evening, a village council hears the land dispute. Satto's goat has died; his daughter-in-law attributes its death to her mother-in-law's curses. The mother-in-law says it is because, despite having vowed an animal sacrifice, the young goats were sold. The narrator describes the maturing figure of Satto's daughter as evidence of contact with men and, with an apparent justification, once again turns his suspicion upon a woman—because such a belief circulates among the people. Satto's daughter has not yet settled in her marital home. While eating at Sukan Ram's house, the narrator feels awkward, and to escape his discomfort says, "Today I have made you a member of my own caste." The Kosi has levelled the distinctions between people: Dom, Chamar, Musahar, Dusadh, Teli and Yadav all fill water from the same vessel and sit on the same mat.

For whom should we write—or tell—a story? The ideological question of storytelling: the people about whom we write may not read it. Will reading stories make people enlightened? The number of those who swear by the Gita and then tell lies has not diminished. Does that mean a story written according to such a criterion has less value?

Even if everyone does not become enlightened, they may at least receive wholesome entertainment. If even one person reads a story and begins to think in that direction, its purpose has been fulfilled. Even when the people for whom it has been written do not read it, those capable of intervening in their circumstances may do so. And as long as these circumstances persist, stories of this kind will continue to be written.

If society changes, will social values remain eternal? Should progressive storytelling reconstruct experience for a changing society, so that natural and social realities may be brought into adjustment with one another? Or does this changing age require stories founded on the enduring, essential elements of tradition, in order to give it some stability? There is a duality between individual welfare and social welfare; the two stand in opposition to each other. They need to be brought into relationship. A worldview is necessary. A story is not simply an idea that has arisen and can be set down anyhow in ink upon paper. It is directed by social and historical conditions.

Should a story, then, be idealist, naturalist or realist? Or should it be humanist, socialist, or a sense-based realism that attaches importance to experience? Alternatively, should a story be purposeful? Such a position would include utilitarianism, experimentalism, pragmatism, causalism, the philosophy of practical efficacy, and consequentialism. This is the most modern standpoint of all. To express oneself is human nature. Yet expression is restricted by social rules and shaped by circumstances.

The story, then, must be fashioned through a reconstruction of experience. Individual consciousness will thereby become social and collective consciousness. The exploiter will be compelled to restrain his tendencies, and the exploited will have to give vocal expression to their opposition.

Freedom—social change. Only then will the story communicate; it will become a medium of dialogue. Only then can the story become a weapon, a force, for society.

If the storyteller preaches, the result will be the transmission of knowledge, which is no longer what is needed. Only when the storyteller initiates dialogue will an atmosphere of liberation emerge; readers who participate in that dialogue will find release from inertia.

The story must be sequential and accessible if it is to achieve this purpose. It must become practical rather than merely intellectual. The generosity of narrative in Vedic literature gave birth to dialogue, which the rigidity of Puranic literature brought to an end.

To re-establish dialogue, the storyteller must possess conviction—conviction grounded in reasoning and conviction grounded in experience. Subhashchandra Yadav possesses both. The analytical philosophy of positivism analyses linguistic propositions and concepts rather than things themselves; this can be seen throughout Subhash's stories. Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism arose as responses to science, and these movements clarified the ambiguous ideas associated with it.

In phenomenology, the givens of consciousness are studied precisely as givens. Experience is the observation of facts pertaining to particular mental activities. This is a means of seeing an object in an absolute and pure form. In existentialism, man is—simply—man. He is nothing apart from what he makes of himself; he is condemned to be free (Sartre). Hegel, through dialectics, emphasised the determination of qualities and judgements of existence by an unending interrelation of analysis and synthesis. The deeper the essential element, the more distant it remains from outward form and the closer it comes to reality.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also affected modern thought. Beyond visible reality, inner and outer processes become possible

through exchanges involving minute elements of force and energy. Under the principle of uncertainty, position and form have to be determined by estimation.

The conception of a universe with more than three dimensions and Stephen Hawking's A Brief History of Time are, in this account, directly undermining the existence of God, for they bring forward the idea of the death of God as well. Thus the existence of a controller of the universe is now in danger. In the context of the death of God and the end of history, how long will Maithili storytelling remain occupied with telling tales? How long will it confine itself to analysing short, very short and shorter stories, tales and fiction?

Just as virtual reality presents reality artificially and unites consciousness with it, so, without conceiving dimensions beyond the familiar three, even if we set out from the time of the Indus Valley civilisation at the speed of light, we could not yet have reached the far side of the universe. This sun is a star of middling rank—a mediocre star—among billions upon billions of other suns. We, living in a town or village on the planet Earth, which circles that mediocre star, sit with our hands upon our heads, worrying: whose problem could be greater than ours? These scientific and philosophical matters present themselves as challenges to our stories.

We shall have to achieve a holistic synthesis, a coordination of the whole! Only then will philosophy move from the merely philosophical to the real.

Poststructuralist methodology locates linguistic meaning not in the word, its meaning, or the rules of grammar, but in the process by which meaning is produced. For different kinds of individuals and groups, language assumes different meanings. There is no final relationship between language and the world. A word and its text possess neither a final meaning nor one exclusively their own.

Modern and postmodern reasoning: modernity was born of reality, dialogue, and the exchange of ideas. Thereafter the New Left movement appeared in France, as did currents such as nihilism and anarchism. These modern systems of thought were based on the distrust that emerged beyond established beliefs and assumptions.

The interpretation of meanings hidden within a text began to take account of its contexts of time and place, and language came to be treated as a form of play—a language-game. Postmodernism appeared as a criticism of power, legitimacy, and their stratification.

Consider the computer and information revolution. A programmer creates a piece of software and places it on the worldwide Internet; thereafter that software goes on working independently of its creator,

sometimes performing tasks for which the creator did not design it. Other, intrusive programs, such as viruses, divert it from its course and make it destructive. Yet antivirus software is itself a program that puts the damage right. If even that cannot repair matters, the computer is backed up and formatted—a clean slate!

Capitalism arose with the Industrial Revolution. Now, in post-industrial society, information and communication have acquired increasing importance in place of production, and the computer has assumed a larger role in society. Mobile phones, credit cards and all such devices are based on chips. During the Kosi flood of 2008, Analkantji was trapped in his village, where obtaining food was a desperate struggle; yet an air-conditioned railway ticket was booked for him with a credit card. What further example could one need of the role of information and computers in Mithila's society?

Deconstruction and reconstruction point to a reorganisation of the process by which thought is formed: consciousness itself is being produced in new ways in the post-industrial age. History has not ended, but traditional history has come to an end. State, class, nation, party, society, family, morality and marriage are all being defined anew. Under the impact of so many changes, numerous institutions have fragmented and lost their contexts.

Against this background, let us also take a searching look at the narrative tradition of Maithili.

Ramdev Jha regarded Jaldhar Jha's "Vilakshan Dampatya" (Maithil Hit Sadhan, Jaipur, 1906) as the beginning of the modern Maithili short story. Then came Pulkit Mishra's "Mohini Mohan" (1907–08); Jansidan's "Tara's Widowhood" (Mithila Mihir, 1917); Shrikrishna Thakur's Chandraprabha; Tulapati Singh's Madanraj Charit; Kali Kumar Das's Adla ke Badla and Kamini ke Jivan; Shyamanand Jha's Akinchan; Shri Ballabh Jha's Vilasita; Harinandan Thakur "Saroj"'s Ishwariya Raksha; Shardanand Thakur "Vinay"'s Tara; Shyam Sundar Jha "Madhup"'s Pratigya-Patra; Vaidyanath Mishra "Vidyasindhu"'s Gapp-Sappak Kharihan; and Prabodh Narayan Singh's Bichhal Phool. The journey was carried forward by Harimohan Jha's stories and Yatri's short novels, and by Rajkamal Chaudhary, Lalit, Ramdev Jha, Balram, Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary, Dhumketu, Rajmohan Jha, Saketanand, Vibhuti Anand, Sundar Jha "Shastri," Dhirendra, Rajendra Kishore, Revati Raman Lal, Rajendra Vimal, Rambhadra, Ashok, Shivshankar Srinivas, Pradeep Bihari, Ramesh, Maneshwar Manuj, Shyam Darihare, Kumar Pawan, Anmol Jha, Mithilesh Kumar Jha, Harishchandra Jha, Upadhyay Bhushan, Rambharos Kapari "Bhramar," Bhuvaneshwar Pathey, Badri Narayan Verma, Ayodhyanath Chaudhary, R. N. Sudhakar, Jitendra Jeet, Surendra Labh, Jaynarayan Jha "Jigyasu,"

Shyam Sundar "Shashi," Ramesh Ranjan, Dhirendra Premarshi, Parmeshwar Kapari, Taranand Viyogi, Nagendra Kumar, Amarnath, Devshankar Navin, Analkant, Shridharam, Neeta Jha, Vibha Rani, Ushakiran Khan, Susmita Pathak, Shephalika Verma, Jyotsna Chandram, and Lalpari Devi.

Is there no good short fiction in Maithili, no good drama? Does Maithili have no grammar? Where, in Maithili grammar, is an analysis of distinctions such as panisoh and panigar, while words such as anal and pavak are readily available? Yet Dinbandhu Jha's book of verbal forms contains 1,025 such genuinely indigenous forms, and Ramanath Jha's Mithilabhashaprakash contains authentic Maithili grammar. With these two reference books, the construction of a standard language and grammar is entirely possible. What happens instead is comparable to writing, in an analysis of the First Battle of Panipat, that the battle was fought between Panipat and Babur. Dhirendra has described Rambhadra as the finest Maithili storyteller; but how many of his stories have been analysed so far? These matters had to be raised in relation to Nachiketa's plays, the work of Mahendra Malangia—the Shakespeare of Maithili—and the narrative journeys of Rambhadra and Subhashchandra Yadav.

At a time when Maithili's problem is its expulsion from household after household, people who have tried their hand at Hindi without becoming known turn to writing Maithili stories and poems and become editors and critics. Under the weight of their ambitions they are burdening the atmosphere of Maithili fiction and poetry. Marxism, feminism and secularism are forcibly stuffed into stories and poems, and the very people who do this proceed to determine their standards; ideology becomes a shield for mediocrity. Those engaged in exploiting and discouraging the poor and people of lower castes seek shelter in Marxism; those who have insulted women take refuge in feminism, the demand for a Mithila state, and related organisations; and communal-minded people find shelter in secularism. One also sees communalists among feminists, opponents of women among Marxists, and many such combinations and literary establishments. Some set about praising Rajkamal, some Yatri and Dhumketu, and some Sumanji; in the guise of taking a position on those writers, they advance themselves. "Even today, Yatri's Paro and the stories of Rajkamal and Dhumketu have not been accepted"—such nonsensical claims are made. Others edit allegedly controversial stories, manufacture a controversy themselves, and thereby promote their own standing. Competition restricted to the writings of Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas is disturbing these poets and storytellers. Having left Hindi for Maithili, they pursue such manoeuvres with such speed that one wonders when they will attend to the language's central problem. Do they imagine that by writing in Maithili after Hindi, recognition will arrive all the

faster? If Maithili writers harbour this misconception, lack confidence and distrust the communicative capacity of their own mother tongue (!), what pretence are we maintaining by placing the future of the language on their shoulders?

At seminars I am astonished to see Sahitya Akademi award-winning, supposedly committed storytellers, editors and critics speaking with their sons, daughters and wives not in Maithili but in Hindi (English, presumably, being beyond their command). When there were twenty people writing in Maithili and five reading it, what controversy could there have been? Having read each of their individual works, I can say that Rajkamal's and Yatri's Maithili writing is gentle in character. In such circumstances, why invent the claim that "this poem" or "that story" contains a controversy, then display one's own brilliance by arguing for it? There follow claims such as "the first novelist after Yatri is so-and-so" and "the first poet after Rajkamal is someone else." Now pairs of storytellers and poets are emerging as well, devoted to one another and promoting each other's positions. Maithili's chief problem is that the language is dying amid the clashing private ambitions of this narrow band of rivals. Poets and storytellers have made Maithili their career: they expel Maithili from their homes and turn it into a subject for seminars. Where, then, are the readers, and what is the point of the controversies? Where do stories and poems stand in relation to what I see as the real problem: providing children with a Maithili-speaking environment and enabling people of every caste to love the language? How many science-fiction stories, and stories and poems for children and adolescents, are these career-minded writers producing? What efforts are being made to take such literature into every home? In an atmosphere where books of one or two hundred copies are printed and reviewed, pieces appear in magazines with circulations of a hundred or two hundred, photocopies are gathered into folders at home, and manoeuvres are undertaken to secure prizes and get books placed on syllabuses, my hopes have come to rest on readers and writers outside the Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha communities.

People who could not manage their own households and families have accumulated heaps of literary and linguistic awards and set out to establish a Mithila state. Who knows how they would administer that state, or in which language they would speak in its legislative assembly when they were honoured there?

People who do not speak Maithili at home have become writers and poets (with equal entitlement in Hindi and Maithili). They think and write in Hindi, then translate it and call the result original Maithili writing! They produce Maithili stories and poems!!

They shamelessly accept awards for translations into Maithili from Marathi, Urdu, Tamil and Kannada, yet if you ask them the meaning of vanakkam, they cannot tell you; they do not know alif, be and se, and cannot converse with a child in Marathi. Their own heads are saved from being cracked by Maithili readers only because they arrange their own publications and reviews—and therefore have no readers. The absence of readers is to their advantage. When members of juries and advisory boards themselves step forward to promote themselves in these prize arrangements, the weakness of this small circle's confidence becomes plain. There is Sarang Kumar, while Balram is once again being discussed as a storyteller. What, then, will happen to writers whose children have not entered literature? Who will revive the discussion of them, who will promote their cause? While they are alive, each is engaged in promoting his own cause, is that not so? But after death? This truth about Maithili literature needs to be brought into the open. People continue searching for a solution even with their eyes closed.

Someone establishes a Chitragupta Sabha and turns Manipadma into a commodity; someone else forms a Maithil (Brahmin) Sabha and begins trading on Sumanji's name. Under the pretext of Manipadma and Sumanji they prosper in their own business and insult the very writers whose names they exploit. The disciples and hangers-on of editors of story and poetry anthologies secure places in collections of Maithili's all-time storytellers and poets—even when they have not published a previous collection or their number of stories and poems is laughably small. The magazines are in much the same state. Engaged in quarrels born of private ambition, these readerless magazines are killing themselves and killing Maithili. Where folk tales are written in drawing rooms without fieldwork, such absurd squabbles are only to be expected. Now caste-based quarrels and abusive language have appeared even on some Maithili blogs on the Internet.

To become a Marxist or feminist and then turn even that into a business, using these labels to compensate for a lack of literary calibre, has become a weapon of less talented writers within this restricted competition. Why should someone who respects Marx feel compelled to announce, “I am a Marxist critic” or “I am a Marxist writer”? What can one say, however, of those who make a business of Marx? The same business is being done in the names of Suman, Rajkamal, Yatri, Manipadma, Dhumketu—and others. The reason, too, is apparent. National surveys show, the argument goes, that Sanskrit, Hindi, Maithili and other literatures are studied at college by people who cannot obtain admission to other subjects; the same people also enter journalism. Such talent-poor servants of literature have acquired a taste for it, and is the future of the Maithili language to be secure in their hands? Yet this reality also opens a path ahead. A category of genuine

Maithili-serving storytellers and readers must emerge—people willing to go among dust and dirt, to create literature for children and women, and to devote their energies to keeping Maithili alive. That category will certainly come into being.

There can be no compromise in Maithili's name. Subhashchandra Yadav's collection was serially published online in the Videha e-journal (http://www.videha.co.in) and won the affection of thousands upon thousands of readers. The stories received online comments; I inferred from readers' surnames that most of them belonged neither to the Maithil Brahmin community nor to the Karna Kayasthas. Another point emerged: lack of education can also produce differences between a language's pronunciation and its reading. That does not mean that Yadavji still speaks the language of Balchanma. If we now use that language for a Yadav character in a story, it may resemble the Prakrit given to ordinary people amid the Sanskrit of the play Shakuntalam; people from that community may even find it insulting. Language is in motion, and the tradition of writing introduces a measure of stability within it. This difference is also evident in Subhash's own writing, between the language of his stories and that of his essays and other prose.

Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas, it is suggested here, cannot remain simply readers for long: they soon begin craving titles such as "the only popular novelist after Yatri" or "the only poet in the true sense after Kulanand Mishra." While calling themselves horses and tigers and other people donkeys and goats, they distance themselves from the essential direction and problems. Their self-satisfied habit of reviewing their own stories and poems has arisen from the weakness of criticism. I have developed an aversion to that word "only," and see a remedy in the Maithili literary movement of the Videha e-journal against the slow poisoning administered to Maithili. More than a hundred writers joined it within a year, while the number of readers exceeded a hundred thousand. The manner in which children and women, along with readers and writers from outside the Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha communities, came together was remarkable. Some will call my emphasis on this a move to divide (Maithili) literature, but my priority is Maithili, the Maithili literary movement. If this language dies, what will become of its fiercely competitive editors, poets, storytellers, critics and advocates of a Mithila state, sitting in their drawing rooms? Reading Subhashchandra Yadav's stories anew and rereading their language attract me all the more in this context. It is also significant that this collection, having first appeared serially on the Internet, is now coming into print: a fresh reading of the stories and of their language accompanies that passage. I hope that events such as these will strengthen Maithili every day and in every respect.

14. Rajdev Mandal's Ambara

Abstract

In efforts to propagate a language such as Sanskrit, simple Sanskrit is used in conversational training camps. Fiction and novels are translated into Sanskrit from modern languages, but poetry is left outside that process. The reason is that nobody reads poetry; translating it into a language for which training camps have become necessary is considered a wasteful use of energy.

Keywords: Rajdev · Mandal · Ambara · literary criticism · Maithili

Poetry: Few people read poetry. In efforts to spread a language such as Sanskrit, simple Sanskrit is used in conversational training camps. Stories and novels are translated into Sanskrit from modern languages, but poetry is excluded from the process. For poetry has virtually no readers, and translating it into a language for which training camps have become necessary is treated as a waste of energy. The situation of Maithili has come to resemble this. If the villages were to disappear today, the number of speakers of the language would become very small. People would speak Maithili only at seminars and gatherings. The need for camps to teach Maithili pronunciation is already being felt. In these circumstances, what is the need or justification for writing poetry in Maithili? When writers emphasise that they compose poetry because they have little time, the situation appears still more alarming. The affairs of the neighbourhood, personal ambitions, accusations and accounts of journeys have become the subjects of Maithili poetry. But why not use prose for these matters? A story may be adapted into a play for the stage, but what is the purpose of transforming prose into poetry? The readers of the poems being written in moments snatched from a busy life are critics given to sycophantic factionalism and the great poets who convert prose into verse while publishing laudatory appraisals of their own poems in prefaces! Who will understand the worth of making verse? A personal, worldly experience that has not penetrated deeply cannot become excellent poetry merely because it rhymes. However abstract otherworldly reflection may be, unless it meets the worldly, it too cannot move us, regardless of free verse, factional praise or the cover provided by an ideology. Human beings need food, clothing and shelter. Only after that comes reflection upon what lies beyond the world. When the Buddha asks whether all the people taking part in a celebration are aware that death is inevitable, and, if they are aware of it, how they can nevertheless celebrate, he poses a question that matters here. Modern Maithili poets see the foundations of their language, culture and economic life vanishing beneath their feet; yet they close their eyes and refuse to acknowledge the fact. They try to force ideologies about events in India and abroad into their poetry and to write for indigenous

and Dalit society as though bestowing a favour. Such work fails to acquire any cutting edge. But when Rajdev Mandal writes—

...
Drop by drop, with drops of dripping blood
The earth is being bathed;
A bird is asking
This question of itself:
Will this dark and heavy night to come
Not leave our kind alive...?

—then the words make us shudder. Whose kind is at stake—the poet's, the bird's, or...? What need has this poem of sycophantic factionalism or a self-adoring preface? What factional chorus or ideological shelter does such feeling require? Poetry, then, needs excellence. It needs foundations in language and culture. It does not need merely imported subjects brought in with the intention of conferring a favour upon it. Nor does it need imported feeling that amounts only to a hurried, condescending attempt to recover the linguistic, cultural and economic foundations disappearing from beneath its feet. A good poem can be written on any subject: on the Buddha's concern for humanity's future, for example, to give strength to an unsettled mind. Otherwise people will continue to flock to fraudulent holy men for sermons. Poetry can attend to the foundations of society's language, culture and economy; otherwise camps will be needed to teach Maithili itself. The communicability of images is essential, too. Otherwise someone must first create an atmosphere for the poet and prepare a platform for the poem; training camps would have to be arranged to explain the poet's vocabulary and ideological allegiance. Indeed, poets have been doing something of this sort already!

The gentle rises and falls of Mithila's language, the many strengths of its working classes, and also its ways of life, cultural rigidity and politics—its daily routines, social conventions, economic condition, morality, religion and philosophy—must all enter literature. Otherwise literature will become one-sided, lose its balance, and turn into something fit only to be framed and hung upon a wall. The writing of poetry is a compulsion, a literary necessity. The day when it is felt necessary to organise camps to teach the people of Mithila their own Maithili language, the existence of poetry itself can be called into question. The poet must remain vigilant so that day never comes.

Rajdev Mandal has remained vigilant in just this way, and therefore his collection Ambara has emerged as the finest Maithili poetry collection of the first decade of the twenty-first century.

Supplementary Discussion

Poetry: Few people read poetry. In efforts to spread a language such as Sanskrit, simple Sanskrit is used in conversational training camps. Stories and novels are translated into Sanskrit from modern languages, but poetry is excluded from the process. For poetry has virtually no readers, and translating it into a language for which training camps have become necessary is treated as a waste of energy. The situation of Maithili has come to resemble this. If the villages were to disappear today, the number of speakers of the language would become very small. People would speak Maithili only at seminars and gatherings. The need for camps to teach Maithili pronunciation is already being felt. In these circumstances, what is the need or justification for writing poetry in Maithili? When writers emphasise that they compose poetry because they have little time, the situation appears still more alarming. The affairs of the neighbourhood, personal ambitions, accusations and accounts of journeys have become the subjects of Maithili poetry. But why not use prose for these matters? A story may be adapted into a play for the stage, but what is the purpose of transforming prose into poetry? The readers of the poems being written in moments snatched from a busy life are critics given to sycophantic factionalism and the great poets who convert prose into verse while publishing laudatory appraisals of their own poems in prefaces! Who will understand the worth of making verse? A personal, worldly experience that has not penetrated deeply cannot become excellent poetry merely because it rhymes. However abstract otherworldly reflection may be, unless it meets the worldly, it too cannot move us, regardless of free verse, factional praise or the cover provided by an ideology. Human beings need food, clothing and shelter. Only after that comes reflection upon what lies beyond the world. When the Buddha asks whether all the people taking part in a celebration are aware that death is inevitable, and, if they are aware of it, how they can nevertheless celebrate, he poses a question that matters here. Modern Maithili poets see the foundations of their language, culture and economic life vanishing beneath their feet; yet they close their eyes and refuse to acknowledge the fact. They try to force ideologies about events in India and abroad into their poetry and to write for indigenous and Dalit society as though bestowing a favour. Such work fails to acquire any cutting edge. But when Rajdev Mandal writes—

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A bird is asking

—then the words make us shudder. Whose kind is at stake—the poet's, the bird's, or...? What need has this poem of sycophantic factionalism or a self-adoring preface? What factional chorus or ideological shelter does such feeling require? Poetry, then, needs excellence. It needs foundations in language and culture. It does not need merely imported subjects brought

in with the intention of conferring a favour upon it. Nor does it need imported feeling that amounts only to a hurried, condescending attempt to recover the linguistic, cultural and economic foundations disappearing from beneath its feet. A good poem can be written on any subject: on the Buddha's concern for humanity's future, for example, to give strength to an unsettled mind. Otherwise people will continue to flock to fraudulent holy men for sermons. Poetry can attend to the foundations of society's language, culture and economy; otherwise camps will be needed to teach Maithili itself. The communicability of images is essential, too. Otherwise someone must first create an atmosphere for the poet and prepare a platform for the poem; training camps would have to be arranged to explain the poet's vocabulary and ideological allegiance. Indeed, poets have been doing something of this sort already!

The gentle rises and falls of Mithila's language, the many strengths of its working classes, and also its ways of life, cultural rigidity and politics—its daily routines, social conventions, economic condition, morality, religion and philosophy—must all enter literature. Otherwise literature will become one-sided, lose its balance, and turn into something fit only to be framed and hung upon a wall. The writing of poetry is a compulsion, a literary necessity. The day when it is felt necessary to organise camps to teach the people of Mithila their own Maithili language, the existence of poetry itself can be called into question. The poet must remain vigilant so that day never comes.

15. Munnaji's Maithili Vihani Story Collection "Pratik"

Abstract

Munnaji's collection of Maithili vihani (seed) stories, Pratik, has itself become a symbol of the symbolic power of the seed story. In every story in this collection one can see the process of lifting rice and chilli seedlings from the nursery bed and transplanting them. It has therefore become a crop of transplanted rice rather than broadcast rice.

Keywords: Munnaji · vihani · story · collection · Pratik · critical theory · Maithili

Munnaji's collection of Maithili *vihani* (seed) stories, *Pratik*, has itself become a symbol of the symbolic power of the seed story. In every story in this collection one can see the process of lifting rice and chilli seedlings from the nursery bed and transplanting them. It has therefore become a crop of transplanted rice rather than broadcast rice. Everyone may have heard of three maunds to a kattha; here we shall see it.

A *vihani* story is not a humorous morsel. It is the root of a story, its seed. There is a great difference between a plant grown from broadcast rice and one raised from a seedling. Broadcast rice does not tiller. A humorous morsel, then, is a little joke: it makes us laugh, but it is like broadcast rice. If one hears that same little joke, that humorous morsel, a second time, one will neither laugh nor be startled by it. If one writes a *vihani* story without allowing it to mature—if one writes it without first bringing it to ripeness—it will remain merely an anecdote. Humorous morsels have, however, been used, and will continue to be used, in seed stories, short stories, longer stories and novels, according to the writer's ability.

Yet seedlings will not emerge in the nursery from parboiled rice. The seed must therefore be sown without first being boiled. It must be brought to maturity without being boiled, and that demands greater labour. Even after one scatters seed, seedlings will not emerge from every grain; some grains will not germinate at all. Thus the proportion of successful seed stories is low; the success rate for short stories is somewhat higher, and higher still for longer stories and novels. A novel, however, is troublesome work: it churns the mind and takes much longer. A seed story can be written at speed. But just as poetry requires an impulse, so does a seed story; without it one cannot simply dash one off, and there remains the danger of making prose out of verse and verse out of prose. Every novelist gathers and arranges a great many seedlings. A novel is prose, but if one of its characters starts singing a song, will you stop that character? A novelist sees a seedling and begins to imagine a flourishing crop of narrative. Sometimes the novelist writes the seed story itself, but then, unable to

restrain the temptation, employs that same seedling in a novel, a longer story, or a short story as well.

What, then, is distinctive about Munnaji's seed stories? My neighbour Surju Bhai raises so many seedlings in his nursery that he cannot transplant even ten per cent of them into his own fields. This is a flood-prone region, so other people's fields often remain without seedlings. Surju Bhai's neighbours benefit from this, because during floods rice sometimes has to be transplanted three times over: one planting is washed away by a flood; a second planting is followed by another flood. Since Surju Bhai is there, people need not worry about obtaining seedlings.

Munnaji's *vihani* stories offer the same reassurance.

Take the seed story "Rewaj" ("Custom"). In village households people call a widow a witch, yet after a man's death they quarrel over the right to light his funeral pyre in order to secure the house-site. Here, however, the seed sown for the story is of a somewhat higher order. The deceased has no son, but he has a wife and a daughter. When his brother wishes to lift the *kohā*, the widow stops him and tells the daughter to lift it. And who will support this new custom, begun only today? The answer, too, is supplied: those who have no sons.

There is likewise the seed story "Kamrunisa." Could Munnaji not fashion from this seed story another excellent novel like *Hasina Manzil*? Kamrunisa's father is Rahman. Like the making of lac bangles, asthma too had become something hereditary in their family. This asthma claimed the lives of Kamrunisa's father and mother, and then Kamrunisa herself...

"Jiya Jaray Sagar Rati" ("The Heart Burns All Night") discusses the problem of AIDS and live-in relationships, while "Diyad" describes how a shoe may look smooth and polished on top yet be eaten away underneath.

"Napna" determines the nature of women's work. Even today, when a census is conducted, the government does not count women's domestic labour as income. The story ends by referring to a woman who both holds a job and performs the work of the household.

"Deh, Mon a Prem" ("Body, Mind and Love") offers an example of how a humorous morsel can be transformed into a seed story. Munnaji works this transformation through two characters named Sabina and Mohsin.

Today, as people's lives gather speed, the importance of the seed story has increased. Munnaji is devoted to the *vihani* story, and this collection is a qualitative expression of that devotion.

Gajendra Thakur

Supplementary Discussion

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16. Sujit's "Jiddi"

Abstract

Sujit's new collection of stories penetrates deeply into the world of feeling. In "Adarsh," the storyteller, Sujit, adopts a female narrator. A distinctive feature of this narration is the injunction: if you have bathed before your husband, scrub the bucket; otherwise your husband's lifespan will be shortened. Hearing this from her mother-in-law, the woman narrator—brought up in the town of Bhairahawa but married into a rural household—wonders about her widowed mother-in-law: if scrubbing the bucket prolongs a husband's life, why did she become a widow?

Keywords: Sujit · Jiddi · critical theory · Maithili

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In "Jiddi" ("Stubborn"), Sharda remembers having had to abandon her dancing and acting midway, and sees the fulfilment of her own purpose in the affection her son Jayant and her daughter Ginni show for dance and acting. Her husband opposes them. The son gives up dancing and acting, but the daughter appears to be realising Sharda's aim. Yet then come alcohol, cigarettes and illicit relationships... The outlook towards dance and acting in the first half of the story moves towards women's empowerment in the second half, but then veers off somewhere else. The son abandons dance and acting, while Sharda's daughter does not. Just as a woman's aspiration is about to find fulfilment through another woman, the subject and purpose of the story unexpectedly drift away.

"Phul Phulaiye ka Rahal" ("A Flower Is Beginning to Bloom") also brings the psychological analysis of a female narrator to the fore. Because her complexion is somewhat dark, she encounters difficulties in finding a marriage partner, but then she meets a handsome young man. There, too, she is betrayed... Yet she pulls herself together, and after a few days everything settles down.

In "Kehan Sajay" ("What a Punishment"), a family abandons its adopted daughter when, late in life, the couple have a child of their own! Here too,

however, as the author tells the story, the love between Ritesh and Chameli is not made clear. The author had no need to specify that the parents who adopted Chameli were Yadavs, for no account of Yadav folk culture occurs in the story. Then, by abruptly announcing a pregnancy, the storyteller cuts the narrative short. A modern story must certainly have a subject, but where layers of problems emerge one after another, the writer must also draw upon vocabulary, everyday social conduct and narrative craft to address them. The writer does enter the layers of feeling; yet, in many places, by remaining content merely to state the subject, the stories seem to have been left unripe. One hopes that the writer's powers will be displayed more fully in a later collection.

Supplementary Discussion

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17. Ramesh Narayan's "Patharak Naw" and Vinod Bihari Verma's "Balanak Bonihar O Pallavi (and Other Stories)"

Abstract

Among Maithili short-story collections, two occupy a special position because of certain distinctive qualities: (1) Ramesh Narayan's Patharak Naw and (2) Vinod Bihari Verma's Balanak Bonihar O Pallavi (and Other Stories). Ramesh Narayan's Patharak Naw was published in 1972 by Upasana Prakashan, 90, Shrikrishnanagar, Patna–1. Vinod Bihari Verma's Balanak Bonihar O Pallavi (and Other Stories) was published in 1994 by Maithili Pratibha, L. F. 1/3, Unit 3, Co-housing Colony, Bhubaneswar–751001.

Keywords: Ramesh · Narayan · Patharak · Naw · Vinod · Bihari · Verma · Balanak

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Ramesh Narayan's "Patharak Naw"

Ramesh Narayan dedicates his story collection thus: "To the mud and mire of my own village, gleaming like a mirror even in fathomless waters, where my hope that a single blood-red lotus might be born and bloom for me remains suspended…" He adds on his own behalf: "Several of the stories in this collection have been broadcast from All India Radio's Patna station; this collection is therefore also offered with the courtesy of All India Radio."

The stories included in this collection are: 1. "The Weary Mind, the Winding Path" (*Thehiyāyal Mon Ghumāon Bāt*); 2. "A Line of Kohl" (*Kājarak Rekh*); 3. "A Palmful of Tears" (*Ānjur Bhari Nor*); 3. "Fragile Sleep, Shattered Dream" (*Kānch Ninn Tutait Swapna*); 4. "The Cherished Bed, the Sacrificed Sleep" (*Saital Sej Nihunchal Ninn*); 5. "Gone Away to a Foreign Land…" (*Teji Gel Bides…*); 6. "The Shade of Thorny Grass" (*Kānt Kusak Chhāhari*); 7. "A Postcard: Sarojini and I" (*Ek Postcard: Sarojini ā Ham*); 8. "Joining the Lines of a Torn Page" (*Chīral Pannā Joral Pānti*).

Vinod Bihari Verma's "Balanak Bonihar O Pallavi (and Other Stories)"

Vinod Bihari Verma dedicates his collection of stories as follows: "Respectfully dedicated to the sacred memory of the revered Lal Bhai, Dr Braj Kishore Verma 'Manipadma', a man of manifold learning." — Vinod. There are fourteen stories in this collection: three appeared in *Mithila Mihir* and eleven in *Vaidehi*. The collection contains: 1. "Balanak Bonihar O Pallavi"; 2. "Kunti, Karna O Parashuram"; 3. "Sulochanak Chatisar"; 4. "Saheb"; 5. "Brahma-Bisun-Rati"; 6. "Ham Pan Khelahun"; 7. "Phulak Katha"; 8. "Antarmukhi Basundhara"; 9. "Kashak Phul"; 10. "Machhak Picnic"; 11. "Jivan-Nao"; 12. "Kapurush"; 13. "Gonaur-Babu"; 14. "Akash-Phul."

18. Some New Books in Maithili

Abstract

Shambhudas — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Jagdish Prasad Mandal enters the minds of ordinary people, and he enters the mind of Barham Baba. Thus he is able to perceive that both Barham Baba and the people are pleased. He sees Shambhua become Shambhu and then become Darbari Das (Shambhudas).

Keywords: new books in Maithili · critical theory · Maithili

Shambhudas — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Jagdish Prasad Mandal enters the minds of ordinary people, and he enters the mind of Barham Baba. Thus he is able to perceive that both Barham Baba and the people are pleased. He sees Shambhua become Shambhu and then become Darbari Das (Shambhudas). Shambhudas's fall beneath a collapsing order is a sign of the disintegration of Mithila's art. The central characters of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's stories neither in Bheṭak Lāvā nor in Bisāṛh are reduced to such disarray; how, then, did Shambhudas become a "courtly" servant? Has some change come over Jagdish Prasad Mandal? Is he growing tired, is he losing the struggle? Yet, seen from a villager's standpoint, Shambhudas is in no way inferior to the heroes of Bheṭak Lāvā or Bisāṛh. Why, then, is he being defeated, or why is Jagdish Prasad Mandal making him lose? After all, he is the author, the god of these characters; why did he not make this one victorious? Jagdish Prasad Mandal's characters are not idle pretenders, and that is why they prevail on the economic front, where work is performed with one's own hands. But they become entangled in the classical labyrinth of art (and literature too), constructed by a handful of people. Shambhudas had to fight his economic circumstances; he fought and won. In the sphere of art he became a courtier's servant, for otherwise he could not make a living. Yet even there Shambhudas raised a flag of rebellion. His decision to forget home and family and never marry demonstrated that becoming a "courtly" servant was not a matter of opportunistic convenience but compulsion. He did not become an opportunist for the sake of a household; his decision to forgo home, family and marriage is also an expression of remorse at having had to become Darbari Das. The parallel tradition will prevent art from being reduced to courtly servitude. If Shambhudas loses, Mithila will lose. It is not Jagdish Prasad Mandal who will lose: Mithila will lose, if Mithila fails to recognise this warning.

Bajantā-Bujhantā — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. In the seed story "Bajantā-Bujhantā," the parrot is a domesticated bird that lives with human beings without a cage. Images of this kind are more numerous in this collection of seed stories than the stories themselves, not fewer. In "Chaukīdārī"

there is the image of labouring for eight months with one's stomach tied tight in hunger. In "Paṭor," dedicated to Manoj Kumar Karna, the well-known Munnaji, the words "Just as a dark room is alive with snakes, so are we two people" push the seed story away from the crossroads in another direction and carry it forward. Of the stories in this collection, Samdahi's observation seems particularly pointed: "Many have become listeners to the language of crows."

Taregan — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. These seed stories have neither a "punch line" nor a discrete "image" of the usual kind, because the book is for young children: here the entire story is itself an image. Thus, in "The Vow of Service to the Nation," when Subhas Chandra Bose's father says that sleeping on the ground is not enough, the effect upon young Subhas's mind remains unchanged even when he grows up. In "True Knowledge," Bharadvaja declares knowledge greater than heaven. This collection is not only important for children's literature; it also enlarges the scope of the seed-story form.

Gītāñjali — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. In the Uchitpur of "Let Us Go to Uchitpur," everyone's gait and bearing are of one kind, everyone wears the same dress, and there is no distinction between fire and water! The "new-moon full moon" of "An Awkward Form..." says a great deal. "Yār Yau..." is a song of calamity. Its account of everything being swept away in a flood includes the washing away of the mind, thought and consciousness themselves. In "Jug-Jug...," dedicated to Rajnandan Laldas, all doors have been shut in a spider's web. The song collection Gītāñjali, dedicated to Professor Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa," is singable in its very texture.

Rāti-Din — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Baba could not understand the exploits of the barren woman; he dug the earth, planted trees and watered them, and yet did the grove turn haunted and desolate? One who had never seen the soil caught hold of a treetop and reached for the sky! "A Light Task" describes the experience gained from acquiring the knack of doing a task lightly, and, indeed, the experience of encountering an artist's work; it also shows how a world of feeling is created. In the syrup of "Paṭṭā Chhīmī," which makes the heart reel, or in "The Household Pitcher Has Already Sunk," one sees everywhere a new, distinctive form of Maithili verse. This is what makes Rāti-Din remarkable.

Indradhanushī Akās — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. This poetry displays a new and distinctive form of Maithili verse: "Dancing and dancing, it sings a nachārī." The spiritual and otherworldly reflection that poetry can contain is also present: "One creation, another desolation / change is only a game." The poet is attentive in the choice of words and subjects. Mystery, despair and questions continually appear alongside answers and hope.

Tīn Jeṭh Egāraham Māgh — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. In "In Every Home...," a lamp burns in each household while darkness spreads across the whole village, creating a duality. "When Skill..." also offers the cause in the lines, "Good ways and bad, ridges and furrows / the land keeps turning barren." Yet in "With Hope and Love..." hope returns.

Saritā — Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Jagdish Prasad Mandal's verse raises questions. Having examined its subject, it brings a question into its conclusion. Viewed alongside his prose writing, despair appears more frequently than hope. Verse does not give him the leisure to analyse either the question or its answer, so through his poetry he inspires readers to keep asking questions and searching for answers. This distinctive form of verse has entered Maithili literature for the first time.

Basandhurā — Rajdev Mandal. When Rajdev Mandal writes poetry, it makes us shiver. His sensibility needs neither the support of a clique nor of any ideological camp. The excellence of his verse comes from its linguistic and cultural grounding, not from imported subject matter; nor, therefore, will one encounter an imported sensibility. The power of his imagery to communicate lies in his vocabulary. To compose poetry is a compulsion for Rajdev Mandal, a literary compulsion. Feeling turns and surges outward, and becomes his verse.

Sakhārī-Peṭārī — Nand Vilas Rai. Writing about Jitan Mukhiya in "The True Son," he says: "A Mallah by caste, yet without the slightest skill in catching fish!" In "The Curd of Chaurchan," Somni gives half the milk to the woman who comes to warm it. In "Babādham" the writer says, "For me, my mother and father are my Babādham." Nand Vilas Rai finds his subject matter in the neighbourhood around him. Dukhni of "The Dung-Gatherer" begins gathering dung from fallow ground, shaping dung cakes and selling them in Nirmali market to sustain herself. As the use of gas increases, dung cakes sell less readily and her life becomes difficult. In "Cleaning the Lying-in Room," people fight over the work of cleaning; many may not know why there is a fight over it, but the reason is that it generates income. Nand Vilas Rai's collection of short-short stories contains many possibilities still concealed, and what has been brought before us is by no means lacking in interest.

Anshu — Shivkumar Jha "Tillu." Meaningful critics have been almost absent from Maithili literature. This is the first book in which the critic begins with criticism and ends with criticism. Unlike critics who begin with applause or denunciation, plead lack of time, and habitually lavish excessive praise or excessive blame, composing without reading such reviews that they could be fitted to any story, poem, novel or play at will, Anshu opens a new chapter in Maithili criticism and announces the end of the old, dilapidated critical practice. In the preface the critic himself says:

"In criticism, looking only on all four sides is not enough; it is right to look in all ten directions." After reading criticism conducted from these ten directions, the books collected and edited by government institutions will seem stale, and the reviews of today's so-called established critics will seem unethical. This is why that kind of criticism has failed to "increase the creator's creative eloquence": good writers have been pushed to the margins of Maithili literature, opportunists have become trapped in a narrow well-bound outlook through such reviews, and the books collected and edited by government institutions have rotted in warehouses because they never received the affection of readers.

In this respect the criticism contained in Anshu becomes still more significant.

Bāp Bhel Pittī and Adhikār — Bechan Thakur. Bāp Bhel Pittī is a social play in which Santosh begs to educate Manoj and then returns home. Adhikār is a play based on the Right to Information. It tells the story of the real-life figure Manjur, who used the RTI law to expose irregularities in the Indira Awas housing scheme and travelled by rickshaw from Jhanjharpur to Delhi. He could not be erased, although attempts were being made to erase him. Why was this happening, whose interests were threatened by the play, and why was opposition to it so fierce? All this has now become clear.

Biswāsghāt — Bechan Thakur. The play Biswāsghāt announces the beginning of Bechan Thakur's second innings. It is his largest play so far. In their choice of subjects, mainstream playwrights still cling to "Gonu Jha" and "folk tales," without bringing those tales into a contemporary context. Mainstream critics then forcibly discover women's discourse and a host of other supposed themes in them, keeping playwrights as frogs in a well. In these circumstances, this playwright of the parallel current has made into the subject of a drama the happenings and misfortunes surrounding compensation money under the present "N.H." road project. The ugly face of the police and administration comes to the fore. The playwright also received threats intended to prevent the staging of the play,

but he did not abandon his commitment as a writer. At the Videha Theatre Festival, the performance ran for more than six hours, and the audience remained spellbound. Bechan Thakur has already written plays about female foeticide, superstition and the Right to Information. His drama on the National Highway project proves that playwrights in the parallel tradition live among the people and remain connected with society.

Hamar Ṭol — Rajdev Mandal. Yatri's Pāro was a "first-hand" account written from within the social and cultural conditions of Mithila's Brahmin caste at the time. Rajdev Mandal's novel is written from within the social and cultural conditions of Mithila's Dhanuk caste. Superstition, social reform, love, hatred, hope and despair are all interwoven here. After Lalit's Prithvīputra, a darkness had spread; mainstream authors and critics had lost their way. Rajdev Mandal's Hamar Ṭol refines the "second-hand" account of Prithvīputra with a "first-hand" account, carrying the course of Maithili literature forward. The author was compelled to make his novel a tragedy. There are certain struggles he does not see, or does not wish to see, and which nobody sees. Yet he gives an account of those too: "Everyone set off in a flurry. The fight between the crow and the myna began. Nobody saw it, but the tree did. And though the tree saw much else, it remained silent." Through its portrayal of the tangle of that silence, refined by a "first-hand" account of what remains unseen, this novel has secured its place in the history of Maithili literature.

19. The Story of "Sagar Rati Deep Jaray"

Abstract

In the history of Sagar Rati Deep Jaray being presented by Raman, there are many discrepancies, from the account of its beginnings to the account of the present day. In telling that history, the contributions of many people have been exaggerated, those of many others reduced, still others altered, and some people have disappeared altogether. It has been described as an autonomous organisation; nevertheless, Raman and Ajit Azad repeatedly took part on behalf of Chetna Samiti. Where no one else accepted the garland, they accepted it on Chetna Samiti's behalf, while the name of Chetna Samiti was omitted from the list of conveners and another name inserted to construct a different history.

Keywords: Sagar Rati Deep Jaray · history · critical theory · Maithili

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What was in the Sagar Rati register that Raman says Vibha Rani lost? Was the register lost, or was it allowed to be lost? Yet there is something, the author says, that neither Raman nor Vibha Rani knows: two or three days before her death, Aarti Kumari sent a photocopy of it to Umesh Mandal. If she had wished, she could have sent it to any of the Jha figures as well, but she did not trust them. Why did she not trust them? It is said that blood always leaves its traces. The true history of Sagar Rati will soon emerge.

The Darbhanga gathering scheduled for 31 May 2014, the author predicts, will be sponsored by Darihare, Raman and Bihari, with the Sahitya Akademi and Maithili organisations recognised by it that the author

describes as fraudulent; it will involve those whom he denounces as casteist, Brahminist and Kayasthaist so-called writers. It will be the second gathering of this kind after Delhi, and Raman, Darihare and Bihari will call it the eighty-third gathering as well. Stories such as "Rāṛak Sukh Balāy" will be read there. Raman, Darihare and Bihari, whom the author describes in the same terms, are barred from the gathering at Mehath.

It is said that Sagar Rati Deep Jaray acts as a training ground for new storytellers, that young writers are given practice in writing. But what is the truth? Are its tendencies any different from those of the Sahitya Akademi? Did the devices employed to take it over not resemble the stratagems used in the Akademi itself?

The boycott of the seventy-ninth Sagar Rati by Hirendra Jha and others, together with what the author calls Raman's casteist pronouncement there, was an affront not merely to Umesh Paswan but to Maithili itself. The politics of seizure of control had begun even before the seventy-ninth gathering. At the seventy-fourth Sagar Rati in Hazaribagh, Pradip Bihari proposed to take up the garland only to defeat someone else's proposal. His proposal was solely intended to secure control for his own group. He withdrew it in favour of that group. He repeated this performance at the seventy-fifth gathering. Was he being used in this practice of blackmail, or was he its leading performer? The essay declares that his writing lacks vitality but his sordid political manoeuvring is vigorous. It alleges that such qualities win Sahitya Akademi awards: he first apologised to Chetna Samiti and humbled himself before it, then shamelessly accepted the award. Thus, the author concludes, he is the principal actor in this business of blackmail. He knows, the essay says, that concentrating on good writing is foolish because it does not bring prizes; a Sahitya Akademi award requires manipulation, at which he is a master. Let Maithili go to ruin.

Under these circumstances new writers received no training. More people were discouraged and driven away from Maithili literature than were brought into association with Sagar Rati: the net result was negative.

The politics of boycott affected the gatherings at Supaul, Deoghar and Narhan. As for the politics of takeover, Manoj Mukti reports that at the Kathmandu Sagar Rati, Dhirendra Premarshi gave no local literary figure even a hint that such a gathering was to take place.

Ashok Avichal, Shyam Darihare, Raman and others allegedly attempted to pressure the Deoghar organiser, Omprakash Jha, by demanding that the Sahitya Akademi gathering be recognised as a Sagar Rati event; they made their participation conditional upon this recognition and threatened to boycott it otherwise. But after what the text describes as the killing of

Aarti Kumari, this was the first chance to defeat those whom the author calls blackmailers. The gathering, sustained by successive reviews and counter-reviews, achieved unprecedented success, and their boycott made it stronger still. Darihare told the organiser that, for the Sahitya Akademi gathering to gain recognition as Sagar Rati, he had telephoned about it at Raman's request during a meeting of the Maithili Writers' Association in Patna. Avichal told the organiser the same thing.

The Deoghar gathering proved to be a training school. Had Raman, Darihare and Bihari attended, they might have learned how to bring quality to their writing. But, the author remarks sarcastically, they are practical people: they understand that one writes only for prizes, and that prizes are won through influence and manoeuvring rather than quality. The essay dismisses Avichal as possessing not even a trace of talent, and argues that no training could have helped him. By staying away he saved his time, and did well to do so.

If Sagar Rati Deep Jaray acquired quality, the essay asks, who would pay any attention to mediocrities such as Bihari, Darihare and Raman? They will therefore hold another Sahitya Akademi gathering with the writer of "Rāṛak Sukh Balāy," where Brahmin youths will be trained by Raman, Bihari and Darihare in how to write "good" stories like that work. So much the better, the author says ironically: fools will cease to enter Sagar Rati. Indirectly, Maithili literature will remain grateful to Raman, Bihari and Darihare for that result.

The strategy of boycott through which Darihare, Bihari and Raman sought control of Sagar Rati was able to work at Bhagalpur with Aarti Kumari; two years later, at Deoghar, the same politics failed so thoroughly that first they withdrew from Sagar Rati and then were removed. What process is operating in this literature, known throughout the world, the author contends, as Brahminist in language, that made this possible? The essay asserts that Aarti Kumari had already been sacrificed by the self-appointed priests of the Brahminist ritual of Sagar Rati Deep Jaray. How, amid that climate of fear, did a transformation occur that Raman, Bihari and Darihare could not understand?

The Brahminist character attributed to the Maithili language has, the author argues, enabled extensive manipulation of language itself. Here rāṛ, as understood from the Brahmin standpoint being criticised, denotes Bhumihars, Rajputs, Kayasthas and all other castes. One addresses one's own child with the respectful yau and an elderly rāṛ with the contemptuous hau! Even proverbs become vehicles of dishonesty: "Ten Brahmins, ten stomachs; ten rāṛ, one stomach." My mother, however, says that this proverb exists only among Brahmins, while everyone else says, "Ten rāṛ, ten stomachs; ten Brahmins, one stomach." The essay claims

that a mediocre writer such as Bihari does not understand these things: he imagines that in "Rāṛak Sukh Balāy," Raman, Bihari and Darihare have directed their insult merely at Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Raman and Darihare, the author says, know what they mean; Bihari, however, is a Kayastha himself, and by Raman and Darihare's definition the insult in "Rāṛak Sukh Balāy" is aimed not only at him but at every non-Brahmin in Mithila as well as at Jagdish Prasad Mandal.

20. Dr Amarendra's "Angika Bal-Sahitya" (Angika Children's Literature)

Abstract

Dr Amarendra's Angika Bal-Sahitya: From Folk Memory to Modern Writing for Children — A Comprehensive Review in Four Dimensions (A Parallel Maithili–Thethi-Angika Study). From Folk Memory to Modern Writing for Children: A Comprehensive Review in Four Dimensions. Book under review: Angika Bal-Sahitya · Author: Dr Amarendra · Samiksha Prakashan, Delhi/Muzaffarpur · First edition: 2022.

Keywords: Dr Amarendra · Angika · children · critical methodology · Maithili

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Pages: 112 · Price: two hundred rupees

1. Introduction: Not a History of Children's Literature, but a Cultural Genealogy

Thethi-Angika: 1. Introduction: Not a History of Children's Literature, but a Cultural Genealogy

Maithili — Dr Amarendra's Angika Bal-Sahitya is not merely, in the ordinary sense, a list of books for children, profiles of their authors, or a chronological record. Its larger undertaking is to understand where and how a child in the Angika-speaking community first encounters literature, and what continuity links those first oral and cultural experiences to modern printed children's literature. Consequently, while writing a history, the book also constructs a kind of cultural genealogy: from lullabies sung in a mother's voice, infant sounds, riddles, play-songs, folktales, and the shared experiences of family and courtyard to modern poetry, novels, stories, plays, essays, and biographies.

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Maithili — The book's table of contents itself confirms this perspective. Its first part, "Angika Children's Folklore," extends over pages 8–42; its second and considerably larger part, "Modern Angika Children's Literature," occupies pages 43–112. The final pages are devoted to references and a list of periodicals. This architecture means that the author does not regard modern written children's literature as an achievement born out of nothing: he seeks the origins of its linguistic rhythm, narrative structure, playfulness, entertainment, and communal memory in folk tradition.

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Maithili — The argument is meaningful also within the wider field of modern children's-literature studies. Kimberley Reynolds identifies the importance of an orally transmitted world of stories in introducing each new generation to literary traditions. In that comparative light, the line of continuity Dr Amarendra draws from folklore to modern creation appears to be an independent critical insight arising from local material. The book's enduring significance lies in making the child's actual cultural life central to the writing of children's literary history: home, mother, grandmother, playmates, birds and animals, fields and open land, rain, river, food, sleep, fear, laughter, rhyme, and bodily movement all become legitimate material for literary history.

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Maithili — Within the parallel-literature perspective represented by Videha, no language's children's literature is considered "minor." To apply the same seriousness of criticism to traditions pushed to the margins of institutional history is a foundational commitment of that movement. From this standpoint, I examine Dr Amarendra's Angika Bal-Sahitya through four dimensions: Indian poetics grounded in rasa, dhvani and vakrokti; Western literary theory; epistemology rooted in Navya-Nyāya; and the Videha framework of parallel history. These four perspectives are not antagonists: they are four angles of illumination upon a single text, together revealing its fuller form.

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Maithili — Dr Amarendra's book is a comprehensive survey of Angika children's literature, distinguished by its attempt to bind together the folk origins and modern development of the genre. In his "Personal Statement," the author modestly acknowledges that it is not a book written independently as one continuous work. Rather, it is a collection of essays composed at different times for the Bharatiya Bal-Loksahitya Kosh (Encyclopaedia of Indian Children's Folklore) and the Bharatiya Lori-Sahitya Kosh (Encyclopaedia of Indian Lullaby Literature), edited by Dr Suresh Gautam and Dr Veena Gautam. His further acknowledgement is critically important: whatever deficiencies remain in the book will open a way for more writing on Angika children's literature. That modest admission already clarifies the work's true character: a point of departure, not the final word.

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Maithili — Literature is a living mirror of a society, a language community, and its cultural heritage. In the case of children's literature, it does not remain merely a collection of stories and informal talk; it becomes a powerful foundation for the psychological, social, and moral development of a new generation. This critical essay offers a detailed literary, linguistic, and psychological analysis of Angika Bal-Sahitya, a work written and edited by the eminent Angika writer Dr Amarendra. Published by Samiksha Prakashan, Muzaffarpur/Delhi, the book is encyclopaedic in its treatment of the development of Angika children's literature, its folk traditions, and its modern tendencies.

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Linguistic and Cultural Relations between Angika and Maithili: Historical Background

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Sankrityayan and later language activists, however, accorded it the status of an independent language. Dr Shobha Kumari's Angika Sahitya Ka Itihas also regards it as a language with a rich tradition. The earliest literary evidence for this language, according to the discussion, is found in the Charyāpada, attributed to the Buddhist Siddhas Luipa, Bhusukupa, and Kanhapa of the seventh century. The passage states that approximately sixty million people speak the language across twenty-six districts of India, in Bihar, Jharkhand, and West Bengal, and that its folklore is exceptionally rich. Reviewing an Angika book in Maithili is thus presented as a way of bringing two sister linguistic traditions closer together.

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Thethi-Angika — 21. Pages 112–114 — References and periodicals. Original content: approximately fifty-two numbered sources and ten periodicals. Examination: the archival mapping is useful, but bibliographic details are inconsistent. Conclusion: a standardised bibliography and index are priority improvements for the future.

Maithili — 22. The whole book — The author as creative writer. Original content: the author is himself a prominent poet, playwright, and novelist, with an extensive body of work. Examination: Bharatavani also carries Shweta Rani's 2021 study and a bibliography of children's songs. Conclusion: inside knowledge is valuable, but the balance of selection needs examination through independent research.

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Maithili — 23. The whole book — Language and style. Original content: the creative material is in Angika, while critical exposition is mostly in Hindi. Examination: accessibility increases, but the autonomy of Angika as a language of criticism becomes a question. Conclusion: the language is straightforward and rich in sources, but the quality of close reading is uneven.

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Maithili — 24. The whole book — Overall value. Original content: folk memory, enlargement of genres, and source lists. Examination: supporting sources adequately substantiate the main conclusion. Conclusion: this is not a definitive history but a foundational reference work.

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2. The Book's Method of Composition: The Strength of Collected Experience and Its Structural Limits

Thethi-Angika: 2. The Book's Method of Composition: The Strength of Collected Experience and Its Structural Limits

Maithili — In his personal statement, the author makes clear that this book was not originally conceived and written as a single, continuous work under one plan. Essays written at different times for edited encyclopaedias and volumes concerned with children's literature and lullabies, previously published material on the Angika language and folklore, and new information added later were revised and brought together to give the book its present form. The author himself acknowledges the possibility of shortcomings. (Original book, p. 6)

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Maithili — This method of composition has two contrasting consequences. First, material accumulated through years of study, collecting, memory, a personal library, and journals and magazines has been gathered in one place. For the literary history of a smaller language community, this is exceptionally valuable, since many sources are scattered across publications that have had little circulation. Second, because the independent essays retain their original structures, the book displays repetition, a predominance of lists, digressions, uneven development, and differences in the depth of criticism.

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Maithili — For this reason, it is appropriate to understand the book not merely as a "linear history" but as a composite of a literary archive, a collection of critical essays, and a survey organised by genre. A revised edition that added conclusions at the ends of chapters, a chronology, an index of authors, genre-wise tables, and editorial treatment of repetition would greatly increase the usefulness of this resource. Both its strength as a compilation and its structural unevenness arise from the history of its making. The principal cause of that unevenness is not the author's lack of knowledge of the subject, but the bringing together of material prepared at different times.

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Structure

Thethi-Angika: Structure

Maithili — The material as a whole is divided into two chapters. The first, "Angika Children's Folklore," studies the oral tradition; the second, "Modern Angika Children's Literature," studies the cultivated or written tradition. This division itself gives structural form to the author's central proposition: whatever is best in modern children's literature owes its quality to having been established on the ground of folk literature.

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The Author: Dr Amarendra's Literary Career and Contribution

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Maithili — Dr Amarendra is a versatile writer in Angika and Hindi who is credited with helping to confer literary distinction upon Angika. Born on 5 January 1949 in the village of Rupsar in Banka district, Dr Amarendra

has, through his literary practice, established standards in the fields of the epic, the shorter epic, children's literature, and criticism.

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Biographical Details and Literary Contribution

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Maithili — Date and place of birth: 5 January 1949; Rupsar village, Banka, Bihar

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Maithili — Dr Amarendra's Angika Bal-Sahitya is divided into two principal parts: "Angika Children's Folklore" and "Modern Angika Children's Literature." It is essentially an expansion of an essay written for the Bharatiya Bal-Sahitya Kosh (Encyclopaedia of Indian Children's Literature), informed by the serious intention of preserving material that had been omitted or remained unpublished.

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3. An Aesthetics of the Child's Mind: The Book's Central Proposition

Thethi-Angika: 3. An Aesthetics of the Child's Mind: The Book's Central Proposition

Maithili — On page 8 the author offers a criterion for children's literature that provides the key to evaluating the entire book. Whether a work has been composed by a child or by an adult for children, the expression of a child's mind must come first. A child's way of looking at objects, thinking, imagination, reasoning, stubbornness, manner of getting demands met, and attraction to pictures and music are treated as elements that determine literary form. The author places direct instruction or the delivery of a message in a secondary position: if there is a message, it should emerge through suggestion, implication, narrative, play, or aesthetic relish (rasa). (Original book, pp. 8–9)

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Maithili — This position is particularly important because children's literature is often regarded as an easy vehicle for moral instruction. In opposition to that tendency, Dr Amarendra grants literary autonomy to the child's world of experience. In his studies of literature's suitability for children, Hans-Heino Ewers asks how literature comes to correspond to children's needs, desires, and values. Compared with that broader

conception, the child-centred criterion advanced in Angika Bal-Sahitya can be understood as a local, intuitive, and practical counterpart.

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Maithili — Yet an intriguing tension also lies within this principle. In the later portions of the book, literature devoted to moral education, environmental education, national consciousness, biography, health, and the rejection of superstition receives considerable praise. Direct instruction is therefore subordinated at the outset, but didactic qualities become important again in the writing of literary history. This is no ordinary contradiction; it is a historical duality within children's literature: pleasure and the inculcation of values, play and education, the autonomous perspective of the child and the expectations of society. The book's fundamental aesthetics is seen at its best when an educational subject is absorbed into children's actions, dialogue, rhythm, humour, imagination, or narrative tension.

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4. Children's Folklore: The Groundwork and a Living Archive

Thethi-Angika: 4. Children's Folklore: The Groundwork and a Living Archive

Maithili — The first part opens out the extensive world of Angika children's folklore. Here literature inhabits not the pages of a book but the activities of life. Lullabies sung while putting a child to sleep, verses sung during oil massage or mealtimes, rhymes spoken during play, competitive

group songs, riddles, humour, animals and birds, and folktales all become part of literature. The author does not leave this material in the vague category of "folk culture"; rather, he attempts to identify its subforms according to age, purpose, rhythm, type of game, and narrative character.

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Maithili — The first significance of this part lies in documentation. Oral material depends for its existence upon memory and living performance; as generations change, the words, tunes, occasions, and rules of games may change as well. Drawing upon available collections, studies, and printed sources, the author constructs a textual archive. An independent literary survey on Angika.com likewise describes the variety and abundance of Angika children's folk verse, observes that much of it survives in oral memory, and regards the collecting work of Naresh Pandey Chakor and Chandraprakash Jagpriya as important. This external evidence supports the archival role of the book.

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Maithili — Its second significance is that folklore is not merely "raw material" for modern literature. The rhythms and melodies of lullabies, the intellectual play of riddles, the pleasure in sound afforded by nonsense rhymes, the collective performance of play-songs, and the changing narrative lives of folktales constitute complete aesthetic systems in their own right. Nevertheless, the structure of the book sometimes risks turning folk tradition into no more than a prelude to modern written literature. A critical reading should also recognise the autonomy of folklore.

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Maithili — The inherent limitations of preservation in writing deserve attention as well. Writing down the words of a play-song does not preserve its melody, beat, bodily movements, rules of play, participation across age groups, season, location, or circumstances of performance. The next phase of research should document an audiovisual folk archive, identifying singers and storytellers, locations, dates, occasions, and variant texts. From this perspective the book is not a completed project, but an initial map for a field archive.

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Textual Survey: Chapter One — Exploring Folk Origins

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Maithili — The greatest strength of the first chapter is its authentic primary material. The author arranges lullabies and children's songs by the occasions of life with which they are associated, from infancy to adolescence: first steps, oil massage, eating and drinking, and being put to sleep. As an illustration, this simple and beautiful song accompanying an oil massage is quoted from Ang-Dhulika:

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> Maithili — "Give oil, ṭaḍuvā; grow, little Nūnū!"

Thethi-Angika — “Give oil, ṭaḍuvā; grow, little Nūnū!”

Maithili — “Let the oilman apply the oil; let little Nūnū grow plump.”

Thethi-Angika — “Let the oilman apply the oil; let little Nūnū grow plump.”

Maithili — “The oil goes chap-chap; may Nūnū grow lap-lap.”

Thethi-Angika — “The oil goes chap-chap; may Nūnū grow lap-lap.”

Maithili — (Ang-Dhulika, p. 8)

Thethi-Angika — (Ang-Dhulika, p. 8)

Maithili — In verses of this kind, the author rightly demonstrates that the life of children’s literature lies not in denotative meaning (abhidhā) but in the suggestive force (vyañjanā) of sound and rhythm: the message emerges through suggestion, not direct statement. This perspective develops further in the discussion of nonsense verse, where the author shows that the apparently meaningless combinations of words in infants’ songs acquire significance through their sound patterns and musical predominance.

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Part One: A Philosophical and Psychological Examination of Angika Children’s Folklore

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Maithili — The folklore of any language is both its unwritten history and a direct mirror of folk psychology. In the first chapter of his book, Dr Amarendra explains what he regards as the psychological and scientific foundations of children’s folklore. He argues that, from a scientific perspective, the infant has already been in a state of sleep accompanied by a particular kind of music while in the womb; a mother’s lullaby, he suggests, echoes that music.

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5. Lullabies, Infant Verse, and the Maternal Voice: Literature's First Threshold

Thethi-Angika: 5. Lullabies, Infant Verse, and the Maternal Voice: Literature's First Threshold

Maithili — The book places the lullaby among the earliest forms of children's literature. Beginning with the relationship among infancy, music, sleep, and the maternal voice, it presents the lullaby as the infant's first literary and musical experience. The crucial critical point is that the lullaby is not simply a text here but a relationship: the joined experience of a mother's voice, an infant's body, rhythm, touch, and sleep.

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Maithili — Before a child reads a printed book, the child receives sound; before understanding meaning, the child responds to repetition, intonation, and rhythm. Lullabies and nonsense rhymes are therefore not an inferior stage in literary development but foundational forms of linguistic experience. The book's examples make family, food, oil massage, sleep, and everyday actions into the materials of poetry. Children's literature begins not with grand fantasy but with the familiar world of the body.

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Maithili — Alongside the central place accorded to the maternal voice, a critical question arises: what part do fathers, grandparents, siblings, neighbours, and other caregivers play in traditional child-rearing? Future field studies, by describing the entire domestic and communal network of children's songs, could give the book's mother-centred material a broader social context. In literary terms, the chief quality of a lullaby is not simplicity but its capacity to be heard: patterns of sound, repetition, short lines, familiar words, and rhythm shape language in accordance with an infant's receptivity.

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Lullabies: A Remarkable Meeting of Tenderness, Music, and Sound

Thethi-Angika: Lullabies: A Remarkable Meeting of Tenderness, Music, and Sound

Maithili — The lullaby is one of the oldest forms of children's literature. It is not merely a means of putting children to sleep: it introduces them to a language's elementary rhythms and sounds. Lullabies preserved in Angika folklore contain exceptionally beautiful images of nature, animals and birds, and familial affection. One may consider this verbatim quotation from the book:

Thethi-Angika — The lullaby is one of the oldest forms of children's literature. It is not merely a means of putting children to sleep: it introduces them to a language's elementary rhythms and sounds. Lullabies preserved in Angika folklore contain exceptionally beautiful images of nature, animals and birds, and familial affection. One may consider this verbatim quotation from the book:

> Maithili — "Ghanā Manjūr, Ghanā Manjūr, where have you hidden, Ghanā Manjūr? Through the forest of twenty-two bighas I shall search for you, wherever you hide, Ghanā Manjūr. Hush now, hush; cock-a-doodle-doo! Little Nūnū, I love you. Come, I will sing a song and put you to sleep."

Thethi-Angika — "Ghanā Manjūr, Ghanā Manjūr, where have you hidden, Ghanā Manjūr? Through the forest of twenty-two bighas I shall

search for you, wherever you hide, Ghanā Manjūr. Hush now, hush; cock-a-doodle-doo! Little Nūnū, I love you. Come, I will sing a song and put you to sleep."

Maithili — A literary examination of this lullaby reveals the combination of onomatopoeia ("chuppā chup, kukrū-kū") and rhythm ("manjūr," "khojī," "gīt") that immediately draws the infant's attention. Dr Amarendra further explains that the child need not fully understand the words of a lullaby: its melody and music, he argues, exert their influence upon the infant mind. The line about "the forest of twenty-two bighas" uses hyperbole with a natural ease that expands the child's imagination.

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6. Riddles and Nonsense Rhymes: Sound Before Meaning, Play Before Knowledge

Thethi-Angika: 6. Riddles and Nonsense Rhymes: Sound Before Meaning, Play Before Knowledge

Maithili — The material on pages 10–14 presents riddles and nonsense verse as two distinct but complementary genres for children. A riddle is a concealed game of meaning: the child joins clues together, guesses, laughs at a wrong answer, and tries again. The reference to forms ranging from a single line to four lines shows how a compact linguistic construction can stimulate intellectual activity. The author also suggests a distinction between the capacities of infants and those of adolescents to grasp these forms.

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Maithili — In nonsense verse, meaning need not be fully apparent. Sound, rhyme, wordplay, repetition, and the pleasure of pronunciation come to

the foreground. The child treats language not only as a system of signs conveying meaning but also as a toy made of sounds. Apparent meaninglessness is not a flaw here: it is a resource for sonic beauty, memory, and participation.

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Maithili — External literary catalogues corroborate the development of printed literature in this field. Angika.com lists Amarendra's Ek Chhari Par Anda Nachai as a collection of riddles composed with children's psychology in mind, and Tuktak-Muktak as a collection of poems for younger children. Kavita Kosh likewise places Tuktak-Muktak in its children's-poetry/e-book category. The book's limitation is that, although examples abound, there is comparatively little sustained close reading of phonetics, the shaping of memory, humour, or linguistic deviation. Future research could examine rhyme schemes, repetitions of sound, word formation, and children's responses across this corpus.

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The Bujhauval Tradition: An In-Depth Examination

Thethi-Angika: The Bujhauval Tradition: An In-Depth Examination

Maithili — The discussion of Angika bujhauval (riddles) is among the most original portions of this book, and it is here that the author's skill in classification emerges especially clearly. He divides riddles into four classes, from one-line to four-line forms, according to the number of lines. This is not merely a numerical division: it conceals a progression in poetics. In a one-line riddle, the entire enigma is compressed into a single image—

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Maithili — "It neither bears fruit nor flowers, yet it winds itself around a tree." (Betel vine)

Thethi-Angika — "It neither bears fruit nor flowers, yet it winds itself around a tree." (Betel vine)

Maithili — Here the paradox "no fruit, no flower, yet it winds itself round a tree" teaches the child to define through negation. It is an elementary lesson in indirect expression (anyāpadeśa) and secondary signification (lakṣaṇā). As the number of lines increases, a dramatic element enters the riddle. In a three-line riddle both resemblance and opposition appear—

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Maithili — "Two companions live together as one;

Thethi-Angika — "Two companions live together as one;

Maithili — One moves, while the other lies still;

Thethi-Angika — One moves, while the other lies still;

Maithili — Yet the two never part." (The two grinding stones of a mill)

Thethi-Angika — Yet the two never part." (The two grinding stones of a mill)

Maithili — In the four-line form, the riddle becomes a soliloquy in which the object to be guessed speaks for itself—

Thethi-Angika — In the four-line form, the riddle becomes a soliloquy in which the object to be guessed speaks for itself—

Maithili — "When I was a tender maiden,

Thethi-Angika — "When I was a tender maiden,

Maithili — I suffered blows all the while;

Thethi-Angika — I suffered blows all the while;

Maithili — Now I wear a red skirt,

Thethi-Angika — Now I wear a red skirt,

Maithili — I will bear no more blows." (Earthen pot)

Thethi-Angika — I will bear no more blows." (Earthen pot)

Maithili — Here an earthen pot recounts its own life in the first person: from a tender maiden to an object baked in fire and clothed in a red skirt. This is the most refined form of the riddle, rising to the level of autobiography and metaphor. Through this progression, the author shows, whether explicitly or not, that Angika riddles are not merely exercises in wit, but a small school of simile, metaphor and indirect expression.

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Maithili — The author's sharpest critical intervention occurs where he excludes complicated riddles constructed so that "one scholar may outwit another scholar" from the bounds of children's literature. That judgement supplies a criterion: a riddle's suitability lies not in its form but in its accessibility to a child's understanding. In other words, the author reads riddles not from the standpoint of collecting folklore but from that of child psychology; this is his methodological distinction. Epistemologically, a riddle is a miniature game of knowing: by hiding the object of knowledge (the answer) behind a screen of resemblance, it gives a child practice in recognising connections and regularities (vyāpti). Yet the book's limitation is revealed at this very point. The author classifies riddles but does not examine their internal structure—the grammar of concealment and answer—the occasions on which they are told, or their comparative position alongside Maithili and Bajjika riddles. The classification is complete, but the poetics of the riddle still awaits its writing.

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Riddles, or Bujhauval, as a Means of Cognitive Development

Thethi-Angika: Riddles, or Bujhauval, as a Means of Cognitive Development

Maithili — As a child approaches adolescence, riddles have held a distinctive place in folk literature as a means of developing logical ability. In children's literature, the riddle is an intellectual exercise. Dr Amarendra classifies Angika riddles into one-line, two-line, three-line and four-line forms. He cites numerous riddles from Aṅgikā Lokokti, Phekṛā Aro Bujhauval, edited by Chandraprakash Jagpriya.

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Classification of Riddles and Quotations

Thethi-Angika: Classification of Riddles and Quotations

Type of riddle · Original Angika riddle (verbatim quotation) · Maithili meaning (solution)

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Maithili — One-line — Original Angika riddle: "It bears no fruit or flower, yet winds itself round a tree." — Meaning/solution in Maithili: betel leaf.

Thethi-Angika — One-line — Original Angika riddle: "It bears no fruit or flower, yet winds itself round a tree." — Meaning/solution in Maithili: betel leaf.

Maithili — One-line — Original Angika riddle: “Neither roots nor leaves: what is it?” — Meaning/solution in Maithili: amarbel, the leafless parasitic creeper (Cuscuta).

Thethi-Angika — One-line — Original Angika riddle: “Neither roots nor leaves: what is it?” — Meaning/solution in Maithili: amarbel, the leafless parasitic creeper (Cuscuta).

Maithili — Two-line — Original Angika riddle: “Needles standing straight on this side / A load borne upon the stalk.” — Meaning/solution in Maithili: a maize plant.

Thethi-Angika — Two-line — Original Angika riddle: “Needles standing straight on this side / A load borne upon the stalk.” — Meaning/solution in Maithili: a maize plant.

Maithili — Three-line — Original Angika riddle: “Two companions live together as one / One moves while the other lies still / Yet they are never parted.” — Meaning/solution in Maithili: the two grinding stones of a hand-mill.

Thethi-Angika — Three-line — Original Angika riddle: “Two companions live together as one / One moves while the other lies still / Yet they are never parted.” — Meaning/solution in Maithili: the two grinding stones of a hand-mill.

Maithili — Four-line — Original Angika riddle: “When I was a tender maiden / I endured blows all the while / Now I have put on a red skirt / I will endure no more blows.” — Meaning/solution in Maithili: a chilli pepper.

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Maithili — A reading of these riddles shows how naturally they employ metaphor and simile. Personifications such as “tender maiden” and “red skirt” make the chilli pepper an object of a child’s curiosity. This is an excellent instance of children’s literature establishing an imaginative identification between nature and human life. The illustrative figure of speech in “needles standing straight” likewise appeals to the child’s mind.

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Tuktak and Poetry for Infants (Nonsense Rhymes)

Thethi-Angika: Tuktak and Poetry for Infants (Nonsense Rhymes)

Maithili — A large part of poetry for very young children is sound-based, or tuktak. Greater stress falls upon the rhythm of sounds than upon literal meaning. Angika children’s literature has an ample stock of what English literature calls “nonsense rhymes.” The author distinguishes pure tuktak from partial tuktak. One excellent instance of the pure form is:

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Maithili — “O re re, little Nunu, or batnā; / Mother and father have gone —chichor kaṭnā. / Father the landlord, on the choṛbā; / Mother the landlady, on the ḍolbā. / Flattened rice crackles in the tray; / Curds are stirred on the hanging shelf.”

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Maithili — Analysing these lines, Dr Amarendra writes that word groups such as “or batnā” and “chichor kaṭnā” have no coherent semantic connection, yet are entirely capable of tickling a child’s imagination. Partial tuktak is a rhyme in which a thread of intelligible meaning continues for a while and then gives way, for no apparent reason, to meaningless expressions. The book offers another striking example:

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Maithili — “I found a pea and hid it beneath my heel; / All seven sisters-in-law are grinding. / One sister-in-law took offence. For whom? / For the old man. / The old man went to the garden; / A crow pecks at his beard.”

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For the old man. / The old man went to the garden; / A crow pecks at his beard."

Maithili — The humour created by "the old man went to the garden" and "a crow pecks at his beard" is very close to the child's world of fantasy. This sort of tuktak particularly delights a child's sensibility.

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7. Play-Songs: Text, Body and Community

Thethi-Angika: 7. Play-Songs: Text, Body and Community

Maithili — The pages devoted to play-songs are among the most vividly alive in the book. Children sing as they play; the song is not an external ornament to the game but part of the action itself. The discussion of optional, competitive and intellectual games, among other forms, shows that engagement with children's literature is not confined to silent reading. Children bring literature to life by speaking, running, counting, choosing, losing and winning, laughing and making rules collectively.

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Maithili — Here the book raises a useful question about performance: where does literature end and play begin? In play-songs, words cannot be separated from bodily movement, group formation, rhythm, place or circumstance. Recording the words alone preserves a text, not the whole performance. For this reason, the book's documentation, invaluable though it is, remains incomplete. That incompleteness is not a personal failure on the author's part but a limitation of the written medium.

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Maithili — Play-songs are also a medium of social learning. Children learn numbers, sequence, selection, rules, taking turns, competition, cooperation, joking and exchanging roles without a formal classroom. Future research that attends to gender-specific games, age groups, the rural–urban divide, seasons, schools and courtyards could draw a more finely differentiated map of Angika childhood culture. The value of documenting folklore becomes especially clear in the context of play-songs: the author has preserved the material; the task of the next generation of researchers is to preserve its melody, movement, setting and social circumstances.

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Play-Songs as a Medium of Physical, Mental and Social Development

Thethi-Angika: Play-Songs as a Medium of Physical, Mental and Social Development

Maithili — Citing the psychologist Karl Groos, the author divides Angika children's play-songs into categories: songs for games involving movement, songs for games played while seated, songs for jumping and running, and songs for intellectual games.

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Maithili — An example of a song used in an active game in which children tickle one another:

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Maithili — "Aṭṭhā-paṭṭhā, Nunu has seven sons— / Rājā, Pātā, Sīt and Vasant. / Kuṭvā, give a push; baṛgaṛ, give a push. / Let me drink water; I shall go to the pond. / Little Nunu says: I shall go beneath the arm."

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Maithili — This song is direct evidence of the competitive spirit and the sense of participation in a group that develop among children during play. A similar competitive impulse is found in Angika songs for the game of kabaddi:

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Maithili — “Enemy, get ready; /I shall race at full speed and cross to the other side.”

Thethi-Angika — “Enemy, get ready; /I shall race at full speed and cross to the other side.”

Maithili — Songs of this kind foster sociability in children, a disposition to live and act within a group, and the capacity to accept victory and defeat with equanimity.

Thethi-Angika — Songs of this kind foster sociability in children, a disposition to live and act within a group, and the capacity to accept victory and defeat with equanimity.

8. Children’s Folktales: Oral Transformation, Narrative Pleasure and Moral Teaching

Thethi-Angika: 8. Children’s Folktales: Oral Transformation, Narrative Pleasure and Moral Teaching

Maithili — The discussion of children’s folktales, beginning on page 25, opens up the book’s narrative foundations. The author recognises that oral folktales are mutable: a story may change form from voice to voice, generation to generation and place to place. Animals and birds, princes and princesses, cunning, fear, wonders, moral lessons and humour appear as traditional materials of children’s storytelling.

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Maithili — This passage matters because the idea of the author changes within the domain of children's oral literature. Authorship is relatively identifiable in a modern written story; in a folktale, collective retelling is itself an act of creation. The storyteller's role, the occasion of telling and the variants therefore become more important than a search for a single "original text." The book offers considerable material in this direction, although it does not systematically analyse tale types, motifs, plot structure, transformations of character or styles of narration.

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Maithili — The question of moral instruction returns here. A folktale may suggest practical intelligence, caution, ethical conduct or consequences, but it is not popular merely because it preaches. Suspense, repetition, wit, impossible events, marvels, deceit, reversals and communal storytelling give pleasure. If the author's earlier theory of the child's mind is applied, a good folktale is one in which instruction is absorbed into narrative enjoyment. The present book is primarily a builder of a corpus: it preserves the existence, kinds and sources of a narrative world; detailed narratological criticism remains a task for subsequent research.

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Children's Folktales: A Mixture of Reality and Imagination

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Maithili — Any review of children's literature would be incomplete without children's folktales. Dr Amarendra maintains that folktales are, in effect, children's literature because their craft and fantasy satisfy the psychology of the child. The book includes an extended discussion of the

history of the Anga region. Referring to Acharya Chatursen and Ramdhari Singh Dinkar, the author recounts the claim that in ancient times people of Anga established settlements or colonies stretching from Champa (Bhagalpur) to Indochina (Vietnam and Cambodia), and that this explains the influence of Angika folktales upon Southeast Asian literature. The text invokes Faxian and Vikramashila University as corroboration of that historical account.

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Maithili — The book discusses collections of folktales such as Chalau Khissā Ke Gāṽ, edited by Meena Tiwari, and Phuljhāmar by Vanchha Bhatt Anjan. It reproduces a full quotation from the well-known Angika children's folktale "Teṅgṭā":

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Maithili — "There was a farmer. One day he bought fish at the market and brought them home. His wife sat down to cook the fish. No sooner had she opened the bundle than a teṅgṭā fish slipped out and hid beneath the grain store. … 'Mother! Mother! From today you are my mother and I am your son. Give me my morning food, and I shall take it to Father.'"

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Maithili — A reading of "Teṅgṭā": the tale depicts the relationship between a teṅgṭā (a species of fish) and a farmer. At its heart is the fantasy, familiar to children, of being able to talk with birds, animals and creatures of the water. When the teṅgṭā takes the form of a boy and works for the

farmer, uses his quick intelligence—with the help of a mouse, a tiger and fire—to teach the king a lesson, and ultimately makes the farmer happy, the tale conveys to the child that even the smallest creature may possess indomitable courage and ability. It delivers this moral without the burden of overt sermonising.

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9. Translation: The Expansion of Children's Literature and the Development of Language

Thethi-Angika: 9. Translation: The Expansion of Children's Literature and the Development of Language

Maithili — In its history of modern Angika children's literature, the book assigns a notable place to translation. Beginning on page 44, the author discusses adaptations of stories suitable for children from other languages, the Sanskrit narrative tradition, Jātaka tales and stories associated with the Bible. This material advances an important historical argument: modern written prose for children begins not only with original writing but also with translation and retelling.

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Maithili — For a literature in a language with limited institutional resources, translation is not a secondary activity. It introduces new genres, increases the range of texts available to children, develops the vocabulary of written prose and brings stories from around the world into local linguistic experience. In this sense, the book's chapter on translation is also a history of language development.

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Maithili — Yet this section invites more extensive future research. The book largely remains at the level of identifying which stories were translated, who translated them and the traditions from which they came. There is relatively little comparative analysis of the source texts and their Angika target texts. Were plots shortened or expanded for children? Were unfamiliar cultural references adapted to local circumstances? How did names, food, religion, humour, dialogue, rhythm and moral conclusions change? These are questions for the next stage of translation studies.

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Maithili — Reynolds discusses the transformation of oral and printed traditions across generations. In this light, a history of the translation of Angika children's literature might be extended beyond journeys between languages to journeys between media—from story to picture book, radio, theatre, audio or digital forms. The original book provides a historical foundation for exploring these possibilities.

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Textual Survey: Chapter Two — The Modern Tradition

Thethi-Angika: Textual Survey: Chapter Two — The Modern Tradition

Maithili — The second chapter is valuable for its historical depth. The author traces the history of translated children's folktales from an eighteenth-century Christian priest (Father Anto Niocour) and his translations of biblical stories, through Grierson's Linguistic Survey of India, to the writings of Dr Maheshwari Singh Mahesh. Along the way, he

discusses the eighteen stories drawn from Sanskrit sources in Angika Kathā-Sarovar (2006) and the contribution of Shri Umesh. In the discussion of original modern poetry for children, he applies thematic classifications—such as poetry depicting nature in motion—and considers poets including Dr Mridula Shukla (Son Chiraiya), Santwana Sah, Dinesh Baba, Aniruddha Prasad Vimal and Chandraprakash Jagpriya.

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Translation Criticism: An Extended Examination

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Maithili — The discussion of translation is the book's second original contribution, offering the outline of an entire history of translation. It is worth observing that the earliest available Angika "translation"—the parable of the Prodigal Son recorded in Grierson's survey—was essentially a missionary and colonial specimen of language, not an indigenous literary undertaking. This raises a major question: is translation a form of linguistic documentation or a form of literature? The book's implicit answer is clear: it removes the Angika translation tradition from the linguist's specimen bottle and places it within the living room of children's literature. The cultural significance of this relocation is considerable.

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Maithili — The most revealing part of this chapter is where the author reflects on his own translations of three Urdu novels for children—Jangal Roṅ Pahchān, Shikār Aro Shikārī and Faisal Roṅ Jāsūsī. Here he develops his theory of translation through practice. He is not primarily a source-oriented translator but a target-oriented one: he deliberately modifies cruel scenes in the original so that children will not be frightened; in Shikār Aro Shikārī, he even introduces a new emphasis on environmental protection and changes the characters' names. This is, in effect, creative re-creation (sense translation), whose criterion is not equivalence but purpose—suitability for children. Translation of children's literature thus becomes adaptation by its very nature; the author establishes this proposition through his own practice.

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Part Two: The Emergence and Development of Modern Angika Children's Literature

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Maithili — The book's second part offers a close analysis of the trends of the modern era of Angika children's literature. In the modern period, writers gave children's literature new directions, ranging from translation to original composition.

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Translated Literature and the Influence of Globalisation

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Maithili — Dr Amarendra explains in his book that the modern journey of Angika children's literature began with translations of stories from foreign and other Indian languages. Notable stages include the Christian missionaries' translations of biblical stories (Mukti Ke Mārg, Sacchā Jīvan Ke Mārg and Yīśu Masīh Ke Kahānī), and, in the modern period, Nandlal Yadav "Saraswat"'s translations of Chinese folktales.

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Maithili — The significance of the Angika translation of the Chinese folktale "Bāṛhi Par Henā Ke Kabjā Pelkai Chīn Deś Ke Mahān Yū": the book presents an Angika adaptation of a story associated with China's Yellow River and the devastation caused by flooding. From the perspectives of environmental conservation and water management, this story is particularly important.

Thethi-Angika — The significance of the Angika translation of the Chinese folktale "Bāṛhi Par Henā Ke Kabjā Pelkai Chīn Deś Ke Mahān Yū": the book presents an Angika adaptation of a story associated with China's Yellow River and the devastation caused by flooding. From the perspectives of environmental conservation and water management, this story is particularly important.

Maithili — "They began thinking of ways to stop the flood. They thought that if a dam were built outside the village, the floodwaters might be brought under control."

Thethi-Angika — "They began thinking of ways to stop the flood. They thought that if a dam were built outside the village, the floodwaters might be brought under control."

Maithili — From a critical perspective, for children in the Anga region—which itself suffers from floods of the Kosi and Ganges—this story of flood management in China is not merely fantasy but a lesson in scientific awareness. Presenting global problems (flooding and the environment) in a local language (Angika) through children's literature is a radical step by the translator and the author of this book. In addition, Dr Amarendra himself translated Sanskrit Pañcatantra and Jātaka stories into Angika in his volume Angika Kathā-Sarovar.

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10. The Children’s Novel: Entry into a Wider Social World

Thethi-Angika: 10. The Children’s Novel: Entry into a Wider Social World

Maithili — The discussion headed “Children’s Novel” on page 51 marks an important expansion of modern children’s prose. Dr Amarendra’s Baṇṭā is examined as an Angika novel for children. According to the book, its narrative offers an extended portrayal of experiences connected with a child’s life, school, teachers, social circumstances and the environment.

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Maithili — The novel differs from the children’s short story in more than length. A longer plot allows a child character to develop over time; relationships among family, school, companions, society, moral dilemmas and surroundings emerge progressively. For this reason, the children’s novel also tests the narrative resources of a language. The independent digital text of Baṇṭā available on Gadya Kosh provides useful external corroboration of the work’s existence. An external list of Angika writers also records Baṇṭā as a novel.

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Maithili — The children’s novel receives less extended treatment than the earlier sections. Nevertheless, the material as a whole makes clear that the novel occupies a noteworthy place in the development of modern Angika children’s literature, even if its corpus is small in comparison with poetry. Future research in this genre might examine character development, experiences of schooling, rurality, children’s autonomy, the narrator, linguistic register and readership by age group.

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The Children's Novel: The Ideological Narrative of Baṇṭā

Thethi-Angika: The Children's Novel: The Ideological Narrative of Baṇṭā

Maithili — The book reviews Baṇṭā (by Dr Amarendra), described here as the only children's novel in the Angika language. It is not a magical or fantastical tale; rather, it concentrates on child psychology, children's indifference towards education, the inhuman conduct of a teacher (Jamuar) and an ideal approach to teaching (represented by the teacher Iqbal).

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Maithili — The most notable feature of this novel is its presentation of the ten principles of conduct offered to children by India's former President and "Missile Man," Dr A. P. J. Abdul Kalam, as the life philosophy of the child protagonist, Baṇṭā.

Thethi-Angika — The most notable feature of this novel is its presentation of the ten principles of conduct offered to children by India's former President and "Missile Man," Dr A. P. J. Abdul Kalam, as the life philosophy of the child protagonist, Baṇṭā.

Dr A. P. J. Abdul Kalam's Principles of Conduct (quoted from the Angika children's novel Baṇṭā)

Thethi-Angika: Dr A. P. J. Abdul Kalam's Principles of Conduct (quoted from the Angika children's novel Baṇṭā)

Maithili — Original Angika quotation: The first principle is: "I shall devote myself wholeheartedly to my studies and work, and become a great person."

Thethi-Angika — Original Angika quotation: The first principle is: "I shall devote myself wholeheartedly to my studies and work, and become a great person."

Maithili — Original Angika quotation: The second is: “From now on, I shall teach at least ten illiterate people to read and write.”

Thethi-Angika — Original Angika quotation: The second is: “From now on, I shall teach at least ten illiterate people to read and write.”

Maithili — Original Angika quotation: The third principle is: “I shall plant at least ten trees and take good care of them.”

Thethi-Angika — Original Angika quotation: The third principle is: “I shall plant at least ten trees and take good care of them.”

Maithili — Original Angika quotation: The fourth principle is: “I shall go to towns and villages and help at least five people give up addiction and the habit of gambling.”

Thethi-Angika — Original Angika quotation: The fourth principle is: “I shall go to towns and villages and help at least five people give up addiction and the habit of gambling.”

Maithili — Original Angika quotation: The ninth principle is: “I shall behave in a friendly manner towards people with intellectual disabilities and those who are physically weak.”

Thethi-Angika — Original Angika quotation: The ninth principle is: “I shall behave in a friendly manner towards people with intellectual disabilities and those who are physically weak.”

Maithili — Original Angika quotation: The tenth principle is: “I shall take pride in my fellow citizens and in the achievements of my country.”

Thethi-Angika — Original Angika quotation: The tenth principle is: “I shall take pride in my fellow citizens and in the achievements of my country.”

Maithili — Baṇṭā establishes an exemplary standard for children’s literature. Its purpose is not merely entertainment but also character building. Presenting Kalam’s principles through a rural Angika-speaking child reflects Dr Amarendra’s progressive and nationalist outlook. The fluency of the novel’s language and the liveliness of its dialogue can hold a child reader’s attention to the end.

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II. Modern Children's Poetry: The Richest Area of the Book

Thethi-Angika: II. Modern Children's Poetry: The Richest Area of the Book

Maithili — The discussion of modern Angika poetry for children is the most extensive, diverse and assured part of this book. From page 61 onward, it brings into view play-songs, nature, children's personalities, social life, national consciousness, the environment, knowledge, rhyme and rhythm, humour, songs based on stories, ghazals, narrative poems and many other forms. The author does not merely offer a catalogue of works; he also comments on their suitability for children, their verbal music, subject matter and imagination, and occasionally on shortcomings in their composition.

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Maithili — Independent literary surveys lend support to this conclusion. Angika.com, noting the abundance of Angika children's folk verse, names five collections of children's songs by Amarendra—Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham, Butru Ke Tutru, Bajai Bin Bajavai Tin, Ek Chhari Par Anda Nachai and Tuktak-Muktak. It also discusses Santwana Sah, Dinesh Baba, Dr Mridula Shukla and other poets included in Angika Balgeet. Bharatavani also lists the 2021 volume Dr Amarendra Granthavali (Volume 1): Angika Balgeet Samagra. The author-centred account in the original book thus finds corroboration in independent publication records.

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Maithili — The richness of this poetry is not simply a matter of the number of books published. The book shows that children's songs range from the delight that sound gives a very young child to an adolescent's social understanding, from nature to science, and from play to an imaginative conception of the nation. Through this breadth, children's poetry becomes a laboratory for modern literature in Angika, where folk rhythms, modern subjects, adult literary forms and the child's consciousness are continually brought into relation and tested.

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Maithili — Yet the question of critical selection is especially acute here. The author is himself a major creator of modern Angika children's poetry, and consequently his own works naturally occupy considerable space. The advantage lies in the testimony of an insider and proximity to the history of publication; the risk is that the relative standing of other poets may be unevenly represented. Future literary histories would benefit from applying comparable criteria to the whole body of texts.

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Textual Survey: Thematic Classification of Modern Children's Poetry

Thethi-Angika: Textual Survey: Thematic Classification of Modern Children's Poetry

Maithili — The third pillar of the second chapter is a thematic classification of original modern children's poetry. The author divides Angika children's poems into several groups by subject. Chief among them are: poetry of nature in motion—moving natural phenomena and living creatures, as in "Jaar," "Dinosaur," "Kosi Maiya" and the poems representing animal voices in Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham; poetry of the regional environment—the geography of the ancient Anga region,

musical instruments and local foods such as the distinctive sweetmeat gatta, in works by Anjani Kumar Suman and others; patriotic children's songs about national figures and festivals, Bharat Mata, the tricolour, Gandhi Baba and Abdul Kalam, including poems by Santwana Sah and Rahul Shivay's Mati Hindustan Ke; poems of knowledge and instruction, including arithmetic and moral teaching—the counting-rhyme "Akkad-Bakkad" in "Lalach Ron Phol" and Sudhir Kumar Programmer's Lur; writing that serves as a workshop in environmental education; and humorous or satirical poetry, including "Piyakkar Mama" and the comic songs of Shambhunath Mistri. From the standpoint of form, he also distinguishes dramatic poetry and narrative songs, such as Dr Abha Purve's "Khayali Pulav."

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Modern Angika Children's Poetry: A New Dawn

Thethi-Angika: Modern Angika Children's Poetry: A New Dawn

Maithili — Collections such as Dr Amarendra's Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham, Butru Ke Tutru and Bajai Bin Bajavai Tin mark a point of departure for modern Angika children's poetry. These collections encompass everything from the world of birds and animals to the wonders of science.

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Maithili — The poem "Boli" ("Voices"), in Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham, depicts the sounds made by different creatures and introduces children to the sound patterns of the natural world:

Thethi-Angika — The poem "Boli" ("Voices"), in Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham, depicts the sounds made by different creatures and introduces children to the sound patterns of the natural world:

Maithili — The owl goes hoo-hoo; the cock gives a crow.
The horse neighs; the saundha goes gar-gar-gar-gar.
The mouse squeaks choo-choo-choo; the dog barks bhoo-bhoo-bhoo.

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Maithili — Santwana Sah's Bajai Chhai Bin, Dinesh Baba's Hansi Bihanki Dhup and Dr Mridula Shukla's Son Chiraiya open new dimensions in Angika children's poetry. The invocation of nature in Dr Mridula Shukla's Son Chiraiya deserves attention:

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Maithili — The earth lay parched, the fields were hungry;
The river ran dry, its sands turned stony.
Clouds gathered and rolled, pouring down rain;
Every pond and pool filled again.
Golden bird, O golden bird!

Thethi-Angika — The earth lay parched, the fields were hungry;
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Maithili — Sudhir Kumar Programmer presents the marvels of science in a manner accessible to children. His verses on the telescope and the radar run as follows:

Thethi-Angika — Sudhir Kumar Programmer presents the marvels of science in a manner accessible to children. His verses on the telescope and the radar run as follows:

Maithili — Bravo, bravo, telescope!
See the distant scene, a bioscope!
There at the border, facing the foe,
Thunderous cannons let their volleys go.

Thethi-Angika — Bravo, bravo, telescope!
See the distant scene, a bioscope!
There at the border, facing the foe,
Thunderous cannons let their volleys go.

Maithili — These poems demonstrate that Angika children's literature is not confined to the boundaries of village and countryside. It is taking up modern science and subjects such as radar and the telescope. This is an indication of the intellectual maturity of children's literature.

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National Feeling and Love of Country

Thethi-Angika: National Feeling and Love of Country

Maithili — The cultivation of national feeling is an important aspect of children's literature. Rahul Shivay's Mati Hindustan Ke is a collection devoted entirely to patriotic songs for children. It celebrates great figures from India's history—Buddha, Mahavira, Shivaji and Subhas Chandra Bose—as well as Tilka Manjhi, the martyr from the Anga region. The following song on the tricolour is moving:

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Maithili — India's glory is the tricolour; it ripples and flies.
At the top is saffron, the blush of morning skies;
It sings the spring-bright honour of our brave martyrs.

Thethi-Angika — India's glory is the tricolour; it ripples and flies.
At the top is saffron, the blush of morning skies;
It sings the spring-bright honour of our brave martyrs.

Maithili — Poets such as Chandraprakash Jagpriya and Anjani Kumar Suman have also emphasised the importance of the mother tongue and the national language in their songs for children. This fragrance of the soil of

the country, present in Angika children's literature, gives children a sense of pride in their culture and their nation.

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12. Nature, Environment and Modern Knowledge: The Power of Expanding Subject Matter

Thethi-Angika: 12. Nature, Environment and Modern Knowledge: The Power of Expanding Subject Matter

Maithili — The discussion of nature poetry around page 71, and the passages on environmental education on page 81, bring out a distinctive aspect of the book's consciousness of modernity. Nature is not simply foliage, rain, birds or the beauty of the seasons; it also becomes a field of environmental crisis, human conduct, education and children's responsibilities. Thus images of nature inherited from folk tradition are transformed into a modern environmental awareness.

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Maithili — In folksong, nature is an inseparable part of the environment of daily life. In modern poetry for children, nature sometimes becomes a conscious subject: something to protect, understand and investigate for its scientific causes. Literature builds a bridge between experience and knowledge. Yet it is necessary to remember the author's initial criterion: an environmental message alone does not constitute a poem. Its literary value will be determined by images, rhythm, humour, questioning, story or dramatic action appropriate to children's minds.

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poem. Its literary value will be determined by images, rhythm, humour, questioning, story or dramatic action appropriate to children's minds.

Maithili — In its discussion of stories on pages 95–96, the book introduces such subjects as modern technical equipment, towers and the dangers faced by birds. The later plays for children reinforce this widening of modern themes through questions of noise pollution, forests, education and health. Reynolds understands children's literature as both initiating readers into society's values and stimulating the imagination of alternative futures. In the Angika examples, environmental concerns give local expression to this dual function.

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Environment, Science and National Consciousness: Literature Attuned to Its Times

Thethi-Angika: Environment, Science and National Consciousness: Literature Attuned to Its Times

Maithili — The purpose of children's literature cannot be regarded as fully realised unless it acquaints the new generation with the urgent problems of the modern age. Angika children's literature meets this standard, in the author's assessment.

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Maithili — Environmental protection: whether it is a poem like "Badal Aro Butru," included in Dr Amarendra's Butru Ke Tutru, or a poem like "Tauhro Ghor," which draws attention to mosquito-borne malaria and filth, cleanliness and the environment stand at the centre of such works.

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Maithili — What sort of home is this of yours?
O mosquito, brother mosquito!
What trade have you learned, tell me?
Will you keep the drains so filthy?
Marshy ground inside the yard and out—
O mosquito, brother mosquito!

Thethi-Angika — What sort of home is this of yours?
O mosquito, brother mosquito!
What trade have you learned, tell me?
Will you keep the drains so filthy?
Marshy ground inside the yard and out—
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Maithili — On water conservation, too, Sudhir Kumar Programmer writes in Dharti Ke Phul: "Do not knowingly waste the water / Keep it, little by little, in every hollow."

Thethi-Angika — On water conservation, too, Sudhir Kumar Programmer writes in Dharti Ke Phul: "Do not knowingly waste the water / Keep it, little by little, in every hollow."

Maithili — Urbanisation and the danger of radiation: in Dr Abha Purve's story for children "Gauraiya-Mai Ke Dor," the deaths of birds, especially sparrows, and the suffering associated with disappearing species are depicted in connection with radiation from mobile towers. When the mother sparrow speaks to her young one, she says:

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Maithili — "What can I tell you now, my child? Our bodies—and especially the structure of our brains—are such that the waves coming from towers and mobile phones have begun to affect our brains badly."

Thethi-Angika — "What can I tell you now, my child? Our bodies—and especially the structure of our brains—are such that the waves coming from towers and mobile phones have begun to affect our brains badly."

Maithili — This exchange is presented not merely as an episode in a story but as a serious warning about imbalance in the ecosystem, one that the work seeks to plant in the minds of the younger generation through children's literature.

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13. Panchamrit, Children's Ghazals and Narrative Poems in Cantos: Experimentation Across Genres

Thethi-Angika: 13. Panchamrit, Children's Ghazals and Narrative Poems in Cantos: Experimentation Across Genres

Maithili — On page 92, "Panchamrit" is discussed as a set of five poetic dramatic works for children. This is followed by a discussion of children's ghazals, where attempts are noted to adapt the ghazal's established adult literary tradition to the world of children; Amarendra and Dinesh Baba are among the names that figure prominently. Around page 91, the tendency toward the narrative poem in cantos (khaṇḍakāvya) is also considered.

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Maithili — The significance of these experiments is that poetry for children need not be confined to short rhymed verses. The ghazal, narrative poetry, the poem in cantos and dramatic forms—all established genres of adult literature—can be recast for young readers. But such an adaptation succeeds only when the genre's outward form accords with the child's capacity to understand, subject matter, sense of rhythm and lived experience.

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Maithili — At times the book raises technical questions of form, but it does not always make its criteria consistent or explicit. A ghazal requires attention to the correctness of its metre (baḥr), rhyme (qāfiya) and refrain (radīf); poetry for children requires age-appropriate vocabulary; and a

poem in cantos requires a convincing movement of the narrative. Each calls for a distinct standard. If a future edition stated its genre-specific criteria at the outset, the evaluations would become more transparent. The historical significance is nevertheless clear: Angika poetry for children is experimental, and the adjective "children's" does not diminish a literary genre. Rather, it poses the challenge of remaking an established form for a new readership.

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Part Three: Children's Drama, Narrative Poems in Cantos and the Craft of the Ghazal

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Maithili — In the concluding portion of the book, Dr Amarendra discusses several particularly distinctive and innovative experiments in Angika children's literature. Drama for children and the narrative poem in cantos are genres in which skill in language and literary construction is put to a demanding test.

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Narrative Poems for Children in Cantos: Ghatotkacha and Panchamrit

Thethi-Angika: Narrative Poems for Children in Cantos: Ghatotkacha and Panchamrit

Maithili — Dr Amarendra is himself an accomplished playwright and writer of poems in cantos. His Ghatotkacha draws upon the Vana Parva of the Mahabharata. In this narrative poem he attempts to capture children's natural fascination with characters endowed with magical and

supernatural powers. In its three cantos—"Manifestation," "Conflict" and "Fall"—the depiction of war and of Ghatotkacha, the son of Bhima, is fearsome yet appealing to the imagination of a child. It is extraordinary:

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Maithili — *He sends all the earth's dust flying,*
He breaks the great trees in his path;
He topples palms and raises rivers,
Makes mountains flow as though they were water;
Dark-hued are the clouds of Sonō,
Like the pitch-dark nights of Bhādo.

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Maithili — Similes such as "flow as though they were water" and "the pitch-dark nights of Bhādo" give the child's mind a visual image. This narrative poem in cantos demonstrates that children's literature need not be restricted to light subjects; it is also capable of epic breadth.

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Maithili — Panchamrit is a collection of five poetic dramatic works for children: Chokar Ke Halua, Atithi Seva, Atmasamarpan, Vishakha and Buddham Sharanam Gacchami. These dramatic pieces were written to impart moral and spiritual strength to children.

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Innovation in the Children's Ghazal

Thethi-Angika: Innovation in the Children's Ghazal

Maithili — The ghazal, originally inherited from the Persian–Urdu tradition and characteristically associated with love and philosophical reflection, is difficult to reshape for children's literature. Dr Amarendra and Dinesh Baba are among the poets who have accomplished this seemingly impossible task. Consider a couplet from a children's ghazal by Dinesh Baba, in which children's various games and the ironies of society are threaded together:

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Maithili — *The cow went to the cowshed (gosallā),*
Drank water at the water-stall (panasallā).
Eyes shut, yet the mind is restless,
Hands move about in the arena (mallā).

Thethi-Angika — *The cow went to the cowshed (gosallā),*
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Maithili — The sonic correspondences in this children's ghazal—gosallā, panasallā and mallā—have the power to draw a child almost unawares into their music.

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14. Modern Stories for Children: An Honest History of Scarcity

Thethi-Angika: 14. Modern Stories for Children: An Honest History of Scarcity

Maithili — From page 94 onward, the book turns to "Modern Angika Prose Literature for Children—Children's Stories." Here the author's critical honesty is particularly striking. The book itself acknowledges that stories for children have not developed as richly as modern children's poetry. Although some distinguished storytellers achieved recognition in

general fiction, they were unable to establish a sustained practice of writing Angika stories specifically for children. The author regards compilations such as Angika Bal-Kahani as important landmarks in the systematic beginnings of the genre.

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Maithili — The clear implication on page 97 is that seven or eight stories cannot, by themselves, make an entire body of children's fiction rich and substantial. This self-criticism is noteworthy, since literary histories often exaggerate the achievements of their chosen subjects. Here, instead, the author turns a deficiency into a challenge for future creation. The book gains credibility as a result.

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Maithili — The thematic diversity of the available stories is important: children's ingenuity, adaptations of folktales, reminiscence, social education, science, the environment, animals and birds, and modern life. The endings of some stories tend toward instructive morals. This is precisely where the earlier criterion concerning the child's imagination must be reapplied: does the story live through its characters, events and dramatic tension, or only through its final message?

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Maithili — The self-critical conclusion of this section matters. At the same time, the weakness of children's fiction should not be attributed

simply to a shortage of writers. It must also be examined in relation to publishing structures, children's magazines, the readership market, adoption by schools, picture-book culture and traditions of editing. A literary genre develops not through authors alone but through an entire institutional ecology.

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15. Children's Drama: A More Significant Field Revealed by Rereading

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Maithili — A close reading of the treatment of drama, essays and biography on pages 98–109 makes it clear that essays and biographies do form a short concluding section, but the discussion of children's drama is both substantial and critical. Children's drama must therefore be recognised as a major achievement in its own right.

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Maithili — Beginning on page 98, the book considers the question of age in children's drama, the boundaries between literature for infants, children and adolescents, and the suitability of the one-act play. The author's argument is practical: children engage readily with a compact form, lively events, dialogue and action on stage. Compared with a long play, a one-act play may be more useful in schools or on a stage intended for young performers.

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Maithili — The discussion on pages 101–105 of the five one-act plays collected in Panchagavya is particularly significant. Social change, policing and administration, opposition to superstition, a scientific outlook, girls' education, marriage and rural life are transformed into dramatic events. On page 105 the author identifies vivid characters, different age groups, the rural setting, dialogue, satire and humour as measures of success. This is not merely a catalogue of subject matter: it pays genuine attention to dramatic craft—character, dialogue and atmosphere.

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Maithili — On page 106, the discussion of the three short plays in Nibhuhān brings to the fore noise pollution, adolescent psychology, the environment and education. Up to page 109, references to radio, musical drama and public health reveal the presence of modern media. Children's drama thus becomes, within Angika children's literature, a meeting ground for social knowledge, public health, environmental concerns and theatrical entertainment. Two especially important directions for further study are the actual performance history of the printed plays and the differences between their written texts and their staging.

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Children's Drama and One-Act Plays

Thethi-Angika: Children's Drama and One-Act Plays

Maithili — The plays and one-act plays written with adolescents at their centre challenge social evils, superstition and problems of education. Dr Amarendra's Panchagavya contains five one-act plays for children:

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One-Act Plays and Their Social or Moral Themes

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Maithili — 1. Karni-Bharni Sathe-Sath — a satire on changing attitudes in the village and political self-interest.

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Maithili — 2. Kalyug Ro Satta — an attack on the dowry system and an affirmation of women's empowerment.

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Maithili — 3. Purano Bhut-Naya Ilaj — scientific thinking in place of superstition, occultism and magical remedies.

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Maithili — 4. Sa Vidya Ya Vimuktaye — the increase in crime, including robbery, in the absence of education, and the importance of learning.

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Maithili — 5. Mutthi Me Dhup — an appeal for women's education and for girls to become self-reliant.

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Maithili — From a critical perspective, these one-act plays acquaint young minds with social realism. The attack on the social evil of dowry in Kalyug Ro Satta—where the heroine herself puts handcuffs on her dowry-demanding prospective husband at the marriage pavilion—is especially capable of awakening revolutionary consciousness among adolescents.

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Maithili — Similarly, Chandraprakash Jagpriya's Vitamin Sabha, a radio play, and Chaturan Ke Chaturai are excellent examples of dramatic poetry for children. The portrayal of Babasaheb Ambedkar's life in Vitamin Sabha and the first-person account of a centipede (gujaraiṭhā) offer children not only entertainment but also detailed information about zoology:

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Maithili — "Look, have you been frightened? … For now I have only a hundred legs. Let me grow a little more; I may develop as many as 380 legs …"

Thethi-Angika — "Look, have you been frightened? … For now I have only a hundred legs. Let me grow a little more; I may develop as many as 380 legs …"

Maithili — To explain, through the dialogue of a centipede, its physical structure (up to 380 legs) and its importance in the ecosystem is presented as one of the greatest achievements of modern drama for children.

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16. Other Children's Literature: Essays, History, Great Figures and Biography

Thethi-Angika: 16. Other Children's Literature: Essays, History, Great Figures and Biography

Maithili — The explicit heading "Other Children's Literature (Essays and Biographical Literature)" on page 109 broadens the book's understanding of children's literature beyond poetry, stories and drama. Pages 109–111 discuss prose suitable for children concerning the principal towns of the Anga region, eminent figures, personalities of the freedom struggle, great figures of India, the Buddha and related subjects. The author regards the transmission of historical and cultural knowledge to young readers as a form of literature.

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Maithili — The criteria appropriate to fiction or poetry are insufficient for assessing such material. In literature of knowledge, the reliability of facts, selection of material, simplicity of language, references, illustrations, chronology and the capacity to awaken curiosity are all important. The book pays particular attention to how illustrations and portraits of notable people can stimulate children's interest. In this sense the section occupies the borderland between children's literature and children's education.

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Maithili — A significant theoretical question arises: does every history or biography written for children count as children's literature? Merely addressing children as the intended readership is not enough. Language, structure, narrative pace, visual material, the encouragement of questions and curiosity, age level and literary presentation become decisive. The book does not develop this question into a complete theory, but it does provide material with which to pursue it. This expansion into essays and biographies clarifies the textual world through which local cultural knowledge is offered to young readers.

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17. Language and Critical Style: Angika Material, Hindi Exposition

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Maithili — The book has a distinctive linguistic structure: the creative examples, titles, songs, story dialogues and the original literary world are in Angika, whereas the critical exposition is conducted largely through Hindi prose. The result is a form of bilingual critical document.

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Maithili — This arrangement has its advantages. Through Hindi, a wider readership—including university researchers and people unable to read Angika fluently—can grasp the outlines of its literary history. Yet a cultural question remains: if Angika is the language of creation, to what extent should its aesthetics, vocabulary of criticism and literary history also develop within Angika itself? A future Angika edition could strengthen the autonomy of the local language of criticism.

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Maithili — The style is generally straightforward, introductory and rich in examples. It avoids a heavy theoretical vocabulary, making the work accessible to ordinary readers. From a research perspective, however, several passages offer more information about works, writers and subjects than sustained close reading. Criticism would gain in depth if metre, imagery, plot, narrator, character development, humour, reader response, age appropriateness, gender and class representation, and the relationship between illustrations and text were analysed by a consistent method.

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Maithili — This limitation should not be taken as a deficiency in the author's scholarship, but understood in the light of the book's purpose. Its first task is to map the field; an exhaustive aesthetic interpretation of each individual work is not its sole objective. The responsibility thus passes to subsequent critics to apply different modern methods to the corpus the author has assembled.

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18. References and the World of Periodicals: The Book as a Literary Archive

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Maithili — The references on pages 112–114 are crucial to understanding the book's value. Approximately fifty-two numbered books and other sources, together with the names of about ten periodicals, bring into view a whole network of literary circulation encompassing children's songs, riddles, stories, novels, drama, translations, biographies, criticism and magazines. Works such as *Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham*, *Butru Ke Tutru*, *Bajai Bin Bajavai Tin*, *Tuktak-Muktak*, *Panchagavya*, *Banta*, *Angika Balgit* and *Angika Balkahani* belong to this bibliographical world.

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Maithili — Bibliographical standardisation is nevertheless necessary. Publication year, edition, page count, place of publication, ISBN and editorial responsibility are not recorded uniformly in every entry. A future edition would become much more useful to researchers if it supplied complete references in a consistent style, together with indexes of authors, titles and genres and a chronological list.

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Maithili — Bharatavani lists the original *Angika Bal-Sahitya* (2022) alongside Shweta Rani's *Dr Amarendra Ka Angika Bal Sahitya* (2021) and *Dr Amarendra Granthavali*, Volume 1: *Angika Balgit Samagra* (2021), edited by Abhinandan. This cluster of related publications suggests that, by 2021–22, Amarendra's writing for children had itself become a focus of criticism, editing and literary historiography.

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19. The Historian as a Creative Writer: Insider Testimony and the Question of Selection

Thethi-Angika: 19. The Historian as a Creative Writer: Insider Testimony and the Question of Selection

Maithili — Dr Amarendra is not an external observer of this literary history. He is himself a poet, writer of children's songs, novelist, playwright, critic and cultural activist. External author lists separately record the publication of works such as *Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham*, *Panchagavya*, *Butru Ke Tutru*, *Bajai Bin Bajavai Tin*, *Ek Chhari Par Anda Nachai* and *Banta*. The book is consequently both a historian's account and a creative writer's testimony about his own field.

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Maithili — Insider testimony has considerable advantages. The writer has direct knowledge of rare books, periodicals, publishing circumstances, contemporary authors and literary institutions. Many little-known works might never enter the historical record without such networks of firsthand knowledge. Yet the witness is also a participant in the events being described; the location of that perspective must therefore be recognised.

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Maithili — Extensive treatment of the author's own works is not necessarily improper if his contribution to the actual corpus is substantial. External sources confirm that he is represented by several works in modern Angika children's poetry. Nevertheless, a future independent history should ask the same questions about every major writer: total output, dates of publication, reception by readers, reprints, formal innovation, language, technique and suitability for child readers. The conclusion is therefore not an accusation but a methodological precaution: acknowledge the value of personal testimony while also undertaking

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20. Books, Periodicals, Collections and Digital Reappearance: The Institutional Ecosystem

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Maithili — Reading the book makes clear that literature is not a two-point transaction in which an author writes and a reader reads. Periodicals, edited collections, literary organisations, publishers, translators, school use, radio and performance, and eventually digital repositories together constitute the ecosystem of children's literature. The list of books and periodicals on pages 112–114 offers concrete evidence of that network.

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Maithili — Available external sources indicate the modern forms of this circulation. Bharatavani lists the original book and related studies or collected works on a government language-knowledge portal. Kavita Kosh places *Tuktak-Muktak* in an e-book or children's-poetry category, while portions of the Angika text of *Banta* are available on Gadya Kosh. This digital reappearance shows printed Angika children's literature entering new media of reading.

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Maithili — The book traces the history through 2022; the field of digital research may have expanded further since then. Future inquiries could ask: which works have been digitised? Which exist as audio? Who reads them in schools and homes? How do children engage with material in their mother tongue on mobile devices? When older play-songs become digital videos, does the performance tradition survive unchanged, or does it assume a new form? In this sense *Angika Bal-Sahitya* is not merely a catalogue of the past but also a baseline against which changes after 2022 can be measured.

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21. Comparative Dialogue with Indian and International Scholarship on Children's Literature

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Maithili — Dr Amarendra's book was not written to imitate Western theories, and its value should not be sought in such imitation. Comparative study can, nevertheless, make its distinctive insights clearer. Hans-Heino Ewers raises questions concerning the classification of children's literature, suitability for children, readers' needs, and the adaptation of values. The importance attached on pages 8–9 of the original book to the child's mind, imagination, reasoning, obstinacy, rhythm, images and indirect communication enters readily into dialogue with this child-oriented perspective.

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Maithili — In her history of children's literature, Kimberley Reynolds discusses its initially educational character, its later diversification into many genres, the initiation of successive generations into literature through oral traditions, and its relationship to a society's values and imagination of the future. Angika material likewise extends from lullabies, tuktak rhymes and play-songs to moral stories and writing about nature, science, the environment, health and social issues. This resemblance does not establish that Angika literary development followed an external model. It shows only that several fundamental questions of children's literature—enjoyment versus instruction, the child versus the adult intermediary, orality versus print, and suitability versus literary freedom—recur across many linguistic cultures.

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Maithili — A comparison among Indian languages could raise similar questions of genre in the children's traditions of Maithili, Hindi, Bengali, Bhojpuri, Magahi and others. But claims of comparative superiority or influence would be unjustified without a dedicated corpus. A sound method for future comparative research would assemble parallel corpora in different languages for the same genre—for example, lullabies, riddles, play-songs or children's stories—over matching periods and assess them by comparable criteria. Exaggeration in the name of proving the worth of literature in a smaller language or related speech variety does not serve literary history. The actual wealth of sources in Angika Bal-Sahitya is sufficient in itself.

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A Four-Dimensional Review: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti; Western Theory; Navya-Nyāya; and Parallel History

Thethi-Angika — A Four-Dimensional Review: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti; Western Theory; Navya-Nyāya; and Parallel History

First Dimension: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti (the Perspective of Indian Poetics)

Thethi-Angika — First Dimension: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti (the Perspective of Indian Poetics)

Maithili — The perspective of rasa: the presiding rasa of children's literature is vātsalya, parental tenderness. In songs accompanying oil massage and feeding, the infant is the ālambana-vibhāva (the sustaining object of emotion), while the mother's touch and gestures are the uddīpana-vibhāva (stimulating determinants). Expressions such as 'Nunu motāy jāy' and 'Baṛhau lap-lap' bring tenderness to fruition as anubhāvas, its expressive manifestations. Even without employing classical terminology, the author arranges these emotional elements in their appropriate contexts and thus makes an unwitting practical application of rasa theory.

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Maithili — The perspective of dhvani: the author's proposition that 'the message emerges through suggestion, not through literal denotation' is a distinctly Angika restatement of Ānandavardhana's theory of dhvani. The apparently meaningless words of tuktak poetry actually produce a sound-centred suggestion, conveying the beauty of resonance rather than a

determinate lexical meaning. In riddles, suggested meaning emerges when the answer is intimated indirectly. In 'Son Chiraiyā', the golden bird that brings rain evokes vastu-dhvani, the suggestion of renewed hope and life amid desiccation.

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Maithili — The perspective of vakrokti: the bujhauval riddle is one of the purest expressions of Kuntaka's oblique expression. A negative formulation such as 'Farai nai phūlai' exemplifies pada-vakratā, verbal distinctiveness at the level of the word; 'Ek saṅ dū sāthī' exemplifies vākya-vakratā, obliqueness at the sentence level. The earthen pot's soliloquy exemplifies prakaraṇa- and prabandha-vakratā: its entire manner of speaking turns obliquely into an autobiography. Indian vakrokti is thus embodied spontaneously in the inventiveness of Angika folklore.

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Maithili — A fuller account of vakrokti: Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita recognises six kinds of obliqueness or striking expression, all six of which can be discerned, layer by layer, in this folk material. (1) Varṇa-vinyāsa-vakratā: the elegance of arranging phonemes, evident in the alliterative music of 'chap-chap', 'lap-lap' and 'ṭūmuk ṭhumuk'; this is the lifeblood of tuktak verse. (2) Pada-pūrvārdha-vakratā: distinctiveness in choosing the root or nominal base of a word, evident in affectionate local expressions such as 'nūnu', 'butrū' and 'gaṭṭā', and in diminutive suffixes that convey tenderness. (3) Pada-parārdha- or pratyaya-vakratā: expressive use of inflection, tense, person and number; the earthen-pot riddle exhibits this in tense shifts such as 'chelām … pahanlā … sahbau' and in its first-person voice. (4) Vākya-vakratā: the oblique configuration of a whole sentence; the paradox 'Farai nai phūlai, ḍhakamorai gāch' suggests the answer by

indirection. (5) Prakaraṇa-vakratā: obliqueness in the construction of an episode, as in the miniature dramatic situation of the pot's soliloquy or dialogue-songs between animals. (6) Prabandha-vakratā: obliqueness in the structure of an entire composition, as in the architecture of refrain and recurrence in a song such as 'Son Chiraiyā'. This sixfold reading suggests that Angika folk poetry for children provides a living, multilayered embodiment of Kuntaka's account of vakrokti.

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Second Dimension: Western Literary Theory

Thethi-Angika — Second Dimension: Western Literary Theory

Maithili — Translation theory: Amarendra's child-protective adaptations illustrate Skopos theory (Vermeer): the purpose of the translation—its appropriateness for children—determines the target text rather than strict equivalence to the source. This is a target-culture-oriented translation in Toury's sense and a 'domesticating' translation in Venuti's terminology. By contrast, retaining Sanskrit verses in the middle of a story leaves a trace of 'foreignisation' that interrupts the narrative flow. It is this defect of foreignisation that the author identifies.

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Maithili — Reader-response theory: children's literature is a vivid domain for Iser's concept of the 'implied reader'. Here that reader is a child, and the translator changes cruel scenes with the implied child in mind. Viewed through Formalism, the bujhauval riddle exemplifies Shklovsky's 'defamiliarisation': familiar things such as a betel leaf, a grinding mill and an earthen pot are made strange so that they may be seen anew. This is a remarkable meeting point between Western defamiliarisation and Indian vakrokti. In the study of folklore, the recurring words of lullabies ('nūnu … nūnu …') provide evidence of the oral-formulaic mode of composition associated with Parry and Lord.

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Third Dimension: Epistemology Grounded in Navya-Nyāya

Thethi-Angika — Third Dimension: Epistemology Grounded in Navya-Nyāya

Maithili — A riddle is a game of pramāṇa, or means of knowledge. Its answer is the prameya, the object to be known, concealed beneath a covering of resemblance; recognising it requires inference prompted by analogy (upamāna), with the apprehension of vyāpti, or invariable concomitance, at its foundation. On encountering the attributes 'climbing round a tree, bearing neither fruit nor flowers', the child infers the intended object, the betel vine, from those marks. A negatively framed riddle such as 'Farai nai phūlai' is practice in inference by exclusion (vyatireki anumāna): alternatives are rejected until a decision can be made about what remains. This is a child's lesson in knowledge through absence, or anupalabdhi-pramāṇa.

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Maithili — Riddles and lullabies are a field of play for all three functions of language—abhidhā (denotation), lakṣaṇā (secondary signification) and vyañjanā (suggestion). The author's distinction between 'denotation and suggestion' is, in another form, an inquiry into the powers of words. Nor is that all: a riddle deliberately produces viparyaya, a mistaken cognition, and its removal generates pramā, valid cognition. In this sense, the riddle is a miniature laboratory for the khyāti debates over the nature of error. In translation, likewise, sense-for-sense rendering preserves not padārtha, the literal meaning of individual words, but tātparya, the speaker's intended meaning. This is an application of the Mīmāṃsā-Nyāya doctrine of intention, and the author reads Amarendra's translation decisions in this light.

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Maithili — The classical foundation for this riddle-inference is located in the discussion of vyāpti in Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi. There, following the examination and rejection of five preliminary accounts of pervasion—the vyāpti-pañcaka or pañcalakṣaṇī—Gaṅgeśa advances his definitive formulation, sādhyābhāvavad-avṛttitva, the non-occurrence of a reason in a locus where the probandum is absent. When solving a riddle, the child is said to grasp this concomitance without knowing the technical vocabulary: wherever the characteristic 'climbing round a tree without fruit or flowers' obtains, there is the intended betel vine. Recognising this regular, inseparable association, the child infers the sādhya from the hetu.

On this account every riddle becomes a small, folk-oriented exercise in the classical question: what constitutes vyāpti?

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Maithili — The five formulations of this vyāpti-pañcaka (here called the siṃhavyāghra-lakṣaṇa) can be examined by name in relation to riddles, because a well-made riddle avoids precisely the defects that an adequate definition of vyāpti must avoid:

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Maithili — (1) Vyabhicārābhāva-lakṣaṇa: pervasion is the absence of deviation in the reason. The alleged defect is mutual dependence or self-dependence, since 'deviation' is itself defined by the absence of pervasion. (A riddle that assumes knowledge of its answer in advance suffers from circularity.) (2) Sādhyābhāvavad-avṛttitva-lakṣaṇa, in a simplified form: the reason does not occur in a locus where the probandum is absent. The alleged defect is non-establishment (aprasiddhi), because with a purely affirmative probandum, such as knowability or expressibility, its absence is nowhere established. (A riddle that offers no contrasting class leaves the child unable to determine an answer.) (3) Samānādhikaraṇya-lakṣaṇa: reason and probandum occupy the same locus. The defect is overextension (ativyāpti), since mere co-location can also hold for a deviant reason. (A riddle offering only one common attribute, such as 'green and growing', fits many possible answers and is therefore ambiguous.) (4) Sādhyavad-anya-avṛttitva-lakṣaṇa: the reason does not occur in anything other than what possesses the probandum. The difficulties involve the complexity of mutual absence (anyonyābhāva) and partial non-establishment (bhāgāsiddhi). (A good riddle excludes competing answers and points in one direction: 'no fruit, no flower, climbing round a tree' eliminates other trees and leads to the betel vine.) (5) The refined definitive formulation:

'pratiyogi-asamānādhikaraṇa-yat-samānādhikaraṇa-atyantābhāva-apratiyogi-sādhya-samānādhikaraṇyam', a refined sādhyābhāvavad-avṛttitva intended to remove the foregoing defects. (A fully determinate riddle, such as the earthen pot's autobiographical utterance, uses a cluster of features to exclude all other answers through complete absence and leave only one. It is presented here as the poetic counterpart of the definitive formulation.)

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Maithili — A rule emerges from this analogy. Just as overextension (ativyāpti) and underextension (avyāpti) invalidate an account of pervasion, ambiguity—the riddle's overextension—and unanswerability—its underextension—damage a riddle. A good riddle, like an impeccable definition of vyāpti, yields one unmistakable answer. This is the unwritten logic of the Angika riddle tradition.

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Maithili — In the context of translation, the theory of tātparya, or intended meaning, is pertinent. Among the four conditions of verbal comprehension—ākāṅkṣā (expectancy), yogyatā (semantic compatibility), sannidhi or āsatti (proximity), and tātparya (intention)—the last, the speaker's intended purport, determines the interpretation. When the primary meaning is obstructed and the intended purport becomes inconsistent with it, lakṣaṇā, secondary signification, comes into play. Sense-for-sense translation follows this route: it sets aside the literal meaning of the words and carries the intended sense into the target language. Amarendra's child-protective adaptation is presented as a practical expression of the primacy of tātparya: it serves the intention rather than submitting to the words.

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Fourth Dimension: The Videha Parallel-History Framework

Thethi-Angika — Fourth Dimension: The Videha Parallel-History Framework

Maithili — A counter-canonical reading: Angika children's literature, a repository of folk, women's, Dalit and rural voices, is largely absent from the Hindi-centred institutional history associated with the Sahitya Akademi. Documenting this material is itself an act of parallel-historical recovery. Bringing women's agency into view is central to such a reading: lullabies are, in the first instance, mothers' creations, a largely hidden tradition of women's literature. In the autobiographical account, the author acknowledges the collecting work of his daughter Vasundhara. Parallel history brings that maternal authorship and women's labour to

the foreground instead of allowing them to disappear into the anonymous category called 'the folk'.

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Maithili — Reclaiming colonial documentation: the translations of Christian missionaries and Grierson belonged to colonial projects of language documentation. This book takes them out of the linguist's specimen jar and returns them to living children's literature. Such reclamation is a central activity of parallel history. Yet the sharpest consequence of the method turns back upon the book itself. A work that constructs a counter-canon is written in Hindi, reaches readers through mainstream publishing, and frequently cites the author's own writings. We must therefore ask who has been left out of this survey: unnamed women folk singers, performers, and the mothers whose lullabies have remained anonymous under the label 'folk'. Parallel history questions even its own counter-canon; therein lies its intellectual integrity.

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Modern Children's Poetry: A Four-Dimensional Re-reading

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Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti

Thethi-Angika — Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti

Maithili — Diversity of themes generates diversity of rasas: adbhuta (wonder) and śānta (tranquillity) in nature poetry, hāsya (humour) in comic songs, and vīra (heroism) together with tenderness towards the motherland in patriotic songs. Yet vātsalya remains the presiding rasa, for the other emotions are softened and offered in forms accessible to children's enjoyment. Viewed through dhvani, 'dynamic nature' is itself rich in suggestion: moving images—not stationary moons and stars but jumping crows and flowing rivers—suggest moving pictures to the child's mind. The author's acute observation that a child is more captivated by a hopping crow than by a motionless moon is, in effect, a child-psychological reworking of the theory of dhvani. The perspective of vakrokti yields a test: in patriotic and instructional songs, direct statement (abhidhā) increases as obliqueness diminishes; in humorous, satirical and dynamically imagined nature poetry, obliqueness and inventive distinctiveness survive.

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Western Literary Theory

Thethi-Angika — Western Literary Theory

Maithili — Dynamic nature poetry resonates with a child-centred empiricism compatible with Piaget: the child comes to understand the world through sensation, movement and activity. Thus the preference for movement over stasis accords with developmental psychology. Patriotic and educational songs, by contrast, exhibit pronounced didacticism. Here appears the enduring tension in children's literature between instruction and pleasure—the contrast, as drawn in the discussion, between a

Rousseau-associated instructional tradition and pleasure-centred writing. Without explicitly stating it, the author inclines towards enjoyment. Comic and satirical songs, with the reversal of conventional portraits of uncles and aunts, are folk manifestations of Bakhtin's 'carnival' and role inversion: humour emerges when the ordinary social order is turned upside down. Regional poetry, meanwhile, bears witness to linguistic and local identity and offers a children's version of contemporary debates about the global and the local.

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Epistemology Grounded in Navya-Nyāya

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Maithili — Counting songs—the akkar-bakkar enumeration in 'Lālac roṅ phol', for example—directly teach the perception of numbers and inferences involved in counting. They are a children's version of training in the means of knowledge. In patriotic songs the message arrives directly through abhidhā. The predominance of literal denotation and the relative weakness of suggestion diminish their poetic quality, in keeping with the author's awareness of the shortcomings of excessive literalism. Dynamic images of nature enable the child to recognise an entity through its attribute of motion. This elementary awareness of the relationship between an attribute and its bearer, and of an action and its locus, contains the seeds of Navya-Nyāya's analysis of qualifier and qualified.

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relative weakness of suggestion diminish their poetic quality, in keeping with the author's awareness of the shortcomings of excessive literalism. Dynamic images of nature enable the child to recognise an entity through its attribute of motion. This elementary awareness of the relationship between an attribute and its bearer, and of an action and its locus, contains the seeds of Navya-Nyāya's analysis of qualifier and qualified.

The Videha Parallel-History Framework

Thethi-Angika — The Videha Parallel-History Framework

Maithili — Poetry rooted in regional surroundings is a counter-canonical affirmation of Anga identity, a voice of regional linguistic pride resisting the dominance of Hindi as the national language. Yet it reveals a two-sided contradiction. Patriotic songs about Mother India and the tricolour reproduce mainstream nationalism: Angika relinquishes its counter-canonical voice and begins to sing in the centre's idiom. On one side stands regional self-affirmation; on the other, self-effacement within the nation. Parallel history attends to this duality. School songs, such as 'Iskūl cal' and poems about Hindi- and English-medium schools, expose the politics of language and class: aspiration for English schooling exists alongside anxiety for the mother tongue. Such songs are invaluable childhood documents of the educational dilemmas of subaltern communities.

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Convergence: The Meeting of All Four Dimensions

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Maithili — The four approaches meet at a single point. The riddle's vakrokti (Indian poetics), defamiliarisation (Western theory), valid cognition achieved through the removal of error (Navya-Nyāya), and the recovery of folk authorship (parallel history) express one truth in four

critical languages: making the familiar unfamiliar can transform the instant of understanding into delight, and the creators of that delight belong to the unnamed people whom history has forgotten. This is the heart of Angika children's literature and, in part, both the achievement and the omission of this book. In modern children's poetry, the same convergence reveals a further dividing line. Where poetry becomes regional, dynamic and humorous, vakrokti, defamiliarisation, suggestion and the counter-canon all remain vital; where it leans towards nationalist instruction, all four lose some of their force. That is the internal criterion proposed here for evaluating modern Angika children's poetry.

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22. Social, Gender and Readership Questions: Critical Territory Beyond the Book

Thethi-Angika: 22. Social, Gender and Readership Questions: Critical Territory Beyond the Book

Maithili — The book touches upon family, the mother–child relationship, rural society, schools, girls' education, superstition, administration, the environment, health and related subjects. On the basis of this material, contemporary criticism can pose further questions. There is no single, uniform experience of childhood: age, gender, class, caste, rural or urban setting, access to school, family structure, disability and linguistic mixture all alter a child's experience. The book does not organise these dimensions into a systematic analytical framework; nevertheless, much of its material makes such an approach possible.

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Maithili — Girls' education becomes a social issue in the plays; the maternal voice stands at the centre of children's oral literature; and rural settings underlie many songs, stories and plays. Future research might ask: How is the agency of girls represented? To what extent do working children, poor households, different social communities and urban children appear? What is the balance between the morally exemplary child and the actually mischievous or obstinate child-character? Do children speak in their own voices, or does an adult narrator speak on their behalf?

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Maithili — The absence of readership research is equally significant. The book often describes a reader's likely response on the basis of the critic's supposition. Future empirical studies—school reading sessions, collective reading, children's responses, preferences and memories, their reactions to illustrations, and the difference between audio and print—could provide literary criticism with new evidence. The purpose is not to diminish the book by measuring it against contemporary theories; it is to make the materials gathered in the book the basis of new research questions. In that sense it is a foundational work.

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23. Principal Achievements: Preservation, the Construction of History and a Map of Genres

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Maithili — The first great achievement of the book, considered as a whole, is preservation. Lullabies, riddles, tuktak rhymes, play-songs, folktales, translations, children's songs, novels, stories, plays, essays and biographies have been brought beneath one critical umbrella. Materials scattered through little magazines, limited editions, oral traditions and private recollections have entered the historical record by name. Without such documentation, later generations of critics might have been deprived of many of these sources.

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Maithili — Its second achievement is the writing of history. The author does not begin children's literature with modern printing; he traces it back to the culture of infants and folk communities. The third achievement is the child-centred criterion. Literature is not simply a vehicle for teaching children: it expresses their imagination, games, reasoning, stubbornness, rhythms and experience. The fourth achievement is a map of genres—riddles, tuktak rhymes, play-songs, ghazals and narrative poems in cantos; novels, stories and translations; one-act plays, short verse plays and radio or musical drama; and history and biography.

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Maithili — The fifth achievement is self-criticism. Acknowledging the inadequate development of children's stories, accepting gaps in certain

areas and pointing out missing sources enhance the historian's credibility. The sixth is bibliographical memory. The concluding lists of references and periodicals transform the book into an institutional memory. For this reason, Angika Bal-Sahitya is not merely a work of literary criticism; it is also a research instrument.

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Merits

Thethi-Angika: Merits

Maithili — The book's foremost achievement is the systematic documentation of a neglected and dispersed tradition. Gathering material scattered here and there, classifying it and presenting it with references is itself an act of scholarship. A second strength lies in the author's dual position: he is himself an important creator of Angika children's songs, and consequently his interpretation possesses an insider's understanding seldom available to an outside critic. Third, the attention to child psychology and a poetics centred upon suggestion lifts the work above a mere catalogue or anthology.

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Overall Evaluation and Literary Significance

Thethi-Angika: Overall Evaluation and Literary Significance

Maithili — Dr Amarendra's Angika Bal-Sahitya is no ordinary book. It is an epoch-making work of scholarship which establishes Angika as a language possessing a rich literary culture. Viewed from the standpoint of a Maithili critic, it makes one aware that the roots of children's literature in

Maithili and Angika are alike. The fragrance of the earth that pervades their folktales, lullabies and riddles is the same.

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Maithili — The book's principal achievements are as follows. (1) Historical documentation: by collecting lullabies, riddles and play-songs disappearing from oral tradition, Dr Amarendra has preserved an invaluable portion of Angika's cultural heritage. (2) Psychological analysis: the work does not merely collect children's literature; the author's examination of its scientific and psychological effects gives it the standing of a research monograph. His perception is remarkably acute, ranging from Karl Groos's theory of play to the phonetic principles of poetry for infants. (3) Breadth and variety: its inclusion of subjects ranging from folktales to modern science, the 'Missile Man' Kalam, ghazals, radar, the environment and flood management is offered as evidence that Angika children's literature is keeping pace with world literature. (4) Linguistic authenticity and fluency: the passages quoted by the author preserve the native Thethi–Desil character of Angika. Whether in the tale Teṅgṭā or in the dialogue of the novel Baṇṭā, the language retains its sweetness and regional vitality.

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24. Limitations: The Dominance of Lists, Uneven Close Reading, Referencing and Selection

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Maithili — To recognise the importance of the work is also to state its limitations plainly. The first is structural repetition, linked to its history as a collection of essays. Similar ideas recur in different sections; the sequence sometimes changes abruptly; and in places the lists outweigh the criticism.

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Maithili — The second limitation is the uneven depth of close reading. The section on the plays collected in Pañcagavya pays sufficient critical attention to characters, dialogue, satire and social settings, but many songs and stories receive no more than an illustrative quotation or brief comment. Comparative conclusions would be firmer if every genre were examined through the same set of questions: theme, language, rhythm or plot, the child's perspective, age-appropriateness, craftsmanship and social meaning.

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Maithili — The third limitation is bibliographical standardisation. The abundance of sources on pages 112–114 is valuable, but full publication years, editions, page numbers, places of publication, ISBNs and the roles of editors or translators are not recorded consistently. A fourth possible limitation is an author-centred corpus. External sources confirm the considerable extent of Amarendra's actual contribution; nonetheless, an independent literary history must accord comparable coverage to other poets and storytellers.

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Limitations

Thethi-Angika: Limitations

Maithili — Critical integrity requires several limits to be acknowledged. The first, and perhaps most telling, contradiction is that a book entitled Angika Bal-Sahitya, devoted to Angika, is itself written in Hindi: its language of criticism is Hindi, while Angika appears only in quotations. The fact that the literature of a language is advocated without being discussed in that language raises a methodological question. Second, the list of 'references' is heavily populated by the author's own collections of children's songs, somewhat blurring the distinction between source material and critical distance. Third, the author himself recognises that this is a collection of essays; accordingly, descriptive enumeration sometimes takes the place of sustained analysis.

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Maithili — A further word about these limitations: the book is complete on its own terms, but the duty of criticism is to consider it from an overall perspective. The author acknowledges the severe shortage of children's stories and children's magazines in Angika. Apart from the collection Angika Bāl-Kahānī, no substantial narrative tradition has yet developed. Children's fiction still awaits the kinds of experiment in the use of folklore that Phanishwar Nath 'Renu' achieved in his writing. The closure for want of money of a children's magazine such as Ajolā Bahin is a matter of concern for Angika children's literature.

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25. Concrete Editorial Proposals for a Future Edition

Thethi-Angika: 25. Concrete Editorial Proposals for a Future Edition

Maithili — Should an expanded critical edition of Angika Bal-Sahitya be prepared, several structural improvements could turn it into a standard reference work without removing the original material. First, retain the present two-part arrangement, pages 8–42 and 43–112, but number its subchapters: lullabies, riddles, tuktak rhymes, play-songs, folktales, translation, novels, songs and poems, ghazals and narrative poems in cantos, stories, plays, essays and biographies.

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Maithili — Second, give each chapter a definition and criteria of evaluation at the beginning and a brief conclusion at the end. Third,

include a chronological appendix identifying the work, author, year, genre and publisher. Fourth, standardise the bibliography of more than fifty-two sources and record publication places, editors and available years in the list of periodicals. Fifth, provide author and title indexes. Sixth, document field metadata for oral materials: collector, narrator or singer, place, date, occasion and variant.

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Maithili — Seventh, include close readings of representative works. Eighth, compare source and target texts in the chapter on translation. Ninth, specify age groups: infancy, early childhood, middle childhood and adolescence. Tenth, supply illustrations, audio QR codes or links to a digital archive, especially for lullabies, play-songs and drama. Eleventh, survey real child readers' responses and school use. Twelfth, follow a consistent biographical format for writers. Thirteenth, provide a complete Angika edition alongside the Hindi critical text, so that Angika can develop its own language of criticism. These proposals do not seek to replace the present book; they indicate how its existing materials can be used more systematically and scientifically.

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26. Overall Assessment: Its Place as a Foundational Work

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Maithili — The greatest accomplishment of Angika Bal-Sahitya is its work of preservation and historical reconstruction. Much of the material might otherwise have remained scattered through oral performance, small periodicals, limited-edition books, translations, private collections or literary memory. Bringing these sources under one critical umbrella is a significant undertaking. Consequently, the book is more than Dr Amarendra's individual work of criticism: it acquires the potential to become an institutional memory of Angika children's literature.

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Maithili — Its second significance is the argument that the vitality of children's literature comes from the child's own world—from rhythm, play, imagination, curiosity, humour, nature, family, friends, questions and experience. Literature is not merely a means of instruction handed down to children from above; it is the art of seeing the world from their perspective. Although the later sections of the book place strong emphasis on instruction, its fundamental child-centred criterion supplies a critical basis for the entire study.

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Maithili — Third, rather than treating folk tradition and modernity as opposites, the book reveals a relationship of transformation: the rhythms of lullabies in modern songs; the narrative resources of folklore in contemporary stories and plays; oral humour and dialogue on the modern

children's stage; and the familiar natural world converted into environmental consciousness. This continuity is the work's underlying historical vision. Fourth, close reading makes an important reassessment of children's drama. Pages 98–109 present it as a significant field for the dramatic treatment of modern social problems, science, education, the environment, health, dialogue and performance.

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Maithili — Available external sources provide substantial corroboration of the original book's main publication details and the existence of the works discussed. Bharatavani lists the original as a work of children's literature published in 2022; the Amarendra-centred studies and collected children's songs published in 2021 indicate an active critical publishing milieu. Supporting sources such as Angika.com, Kavita Kosh and Gadya Kosh offer evidence of the digital or literary presence of major works.

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Maithili — The limitations are real: repetitions inherent in compilation, the dominance of lists, uneven close reading, bibliographical inconsistencies, the possibility of author-centred selection, and the absence of performance data and reader-response studies. Yet they do not make the book irrelevant. They show where the next phase of research should begin.

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make the book irrelevant. They show where the next phase of research should begin.

Maithili — Ultimately, to describe Angika Bal-Sahitya merely as an introduction to writings for children would diminish its importance. It stands at the intersection of folk memory, linguistic identity, the child's world, literary modernity, translation, the expansion of genres and documentation. Its finest passages reveal a cultural continuity from lullabies to modern poetry, play to drama, and folktales to environmental or scientific narratives. It is not a closed or definitive literary history: it is a foundational work for an extensive history of Angika children's literature, textual criticism, performance archives, translation studies and research into children as readers.

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Maithili — In this sense, children's literature is no minor corner of a linguistic tradition. When children play, sing, listen to stories, ask questions, read and perform in their mother tongue, that language does not merely survive into the next generation: it is recreated in new forms. The enduring literary message of Dr Amarendra's book lies in this profound insight.

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Editorial Judgement (Conclusion)

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Maithili — Despite all this, the book succeeds in its stated purpose: opening a path for further writing about Angika children's literature. Its lasting worth lies less in novelty of interpretation than in the reliability of its documentation. In particular, the first chapter's folk material—

lullabies, oil-massage songs, step-songs and riddles—is a dependable resource for future scholars. With characteristic modesty, Dr Amarendra has called his work a beginning rather than the final word, and the critic's judgement points in the same direction. It is a foundation stone, not the pinnacle, of the house of criticism devoted to Angika children's literature. The virtue of a sound foundation is its ability to support the possibility of much being built above it. Viewed through the Videha perspective, the book marks an initial step towards recovering Angika children's literature from the status of a linguist's specimen and restoring it as a living tradition. Carrying that work forward is now the responsibility of the community of critics.

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Conclusion

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Maithili — In the final analysis, Dr Amarendra's Angika Bal-Sahitya is a milestone for Angika and the wider Bihari literary tradition. An unfortunate tendency in academic life has been to consign children's literature to an inferior place on the margins of literature; this research-based book challenges that misconception. It demonstrates that children's literature is a 'factory' for the reconstruction of society.

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Maithili — Maithili literature, too, needs to draw inspiration from this movement in Angika children's literature. The message conveyed by the book—linguistic integrity, scientific preservation of folk traditions and advancing alongside modernity—is exemplary for writers in all regional languages. Dr Amarendra's immense undertaking deserves a distinguished place in the history of Angika literature, and the volume will continue to guide researchers, writers and educationists as a foundational reference.

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27. Concise Summary of the Overall Conclusion

Thethi-Angika: 27. Concise Summary of the Overall Conclusion

Maithili — Reading the entire book shows that, from its preliminary publication details and autobiographical statements to its lists of reference works and periodicals, its range of subjects provides a map of a whole field of children's literature. The principal subgenres of the folk-literature section are lullabies and infant songs, riddles, tuktak rhymes, play-songs, folktales and narratives shared across languages. The modern section covers translated children's tales, children's novels, songs and poems, writings on nature, the environment and knowledge, ghazals and narrative poems in cantos, children's stories, one-act plays and other drama for children, and essays, history and biography.

Thethi-Angika — A rereading of all 114 pages shows that the book's range of subjects, from preliminary publication data and autobiographical statements to its reference and periodical lists, maps an entire field of children's literature. The folk section chiefly embraces lullabies and infant songs, riddles, tuktak rhymes, play-songs, folktales and narratives shared between languages. Its modern section covers translated children's stories, children's novels, songs and poems, writing on nature, the environment and knowledge, ghazals and narrative poems in cantos, children's stories, one-act plays and children's drama, and essays, history and biography.

Maithili — The principal lines of argument developed across this study—cultural genealogy, the compilation of materials, the child's mind, documentation, links between folk culture and modernity, translation, the richness of poetry, the relative scarcity of children's stories, drama and other genres, language, achievements, limits and the book's value as a

foundation—have been preserved in this essay. Special attention has been devoted to reassessing children's drama; analysing the bibliography and periodical world on pages 112–114 as an archive; considering the author's dual role as writer and historian; checking publication information against external sources; comparing theories of child-appropriateness, oral tradition and socialisation; and proposing future work on performance archives, reader response and standardised bibliography.

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Detailed Bibliography

This bibliography includes only books, treatises, dictionaries, collections and literary works issued in book form. Where the material under review does not clearly supply a publication year or publisher, no conjectural information has been added.

A. The Book under Review and Dr Amarendra's Works for Children

1. Amarendra, Dr — Angika Bal-Sahitya. Samiksha Prakashan, Muzaffarpur/Delhi; first edition, 2022. The principal book examined in this review. 112 pages. Price: two hundred rupees.

2. Abhinandan (ed.) — Dr Amarendra Granthavali, Volume 1: Angika Balgeet Samagra. Samiksha Prakashan, Muzaffarpur, 2021. A consolidated book-form collection of Dr Amarendra's writing of children's songs.

3. Rani, Shweta — Dr Amarendra ka Angika Bal Sahitya. Samiksha Prakashan, Muzaffarpur, 2021. A critical study devoted to Dr Amarendra's Angika children's literature.

4. Amarendra, Dr — Dhol Bajai Chhai Dhammak Dham. A collection of children's songs. The material under review does not clearly provide its year of publication or publisher.

5. Amarendra, Dr — Butru Ke Tutru. A collection of children's songs. The material under review does not clearly provide its year of publication or publisher.

6. Amarendra, Dr — Bajai Been Bajavai Teen. A collection of children's songs. The material under review does not clearly provide its year of publication or publisher.

7. Amarendra, Dr — Ek Chhari Par Anda Nachai. A book concerned with children's riddles, games and linguistic curiosity. Publication details are not supplied in the material under review.

8. Amarendra, Dr — Tuktak-Muktak. A collection of sound-centred poems for infants and younger children. Publication details are not available in the material under review.

9. Amarendra, Dr — Banta. An Angika novel for children, centred on an extended narrative world of schools, teachers, the child's mind, social circumstances and the environment. Publication details are not clearly given in the material under review.

10. Amarendra, Dr — Angika Katha-Sarovar. 2006. A book associated with Sanskrit-derived narratives, the Panchatantra–Jataka tradition and adaptations suitable for children. The publisher is not clearly identified in the material under review.

11. Amarendra, Dr — Ghatotkacha. A narrative poem for children in three cantos, based on the Vana Parva of the Mahabharata. Publication details are not clearly given in the material under review.

12. Amarendra, Dr — Panchamrit. A collection of five verse plays for children, including Chokar Ke Halua, Atithi Seva, Atmasamarpan, Vishakha and Buddham Sharanam Gachchhami. Publication details are not clearly supplied in the material under review.

13. Amarendra, Dr — Panchagavya. A collection of five one-act plays for children, addressing social realities, resistance to superstition, education and adolescent awareness. Publication details are not clearly supplied in the material under review.

14. Amarendra, Dr (translator) — Jangal Rong Pahchan. An Angika adaptation of an Urdu children's novel. The original author, publication year and publisher are not clearly identified in the material under review.

15. Amarendra, Dr (translator) — Shikar Aro Shikari. An Angika adaptation of an Urdu children's novel; an example of adaptation for child suitability and environmental awareness. The original author and publication details are not clearly identified in the material under review.

16. Amarendra, Dr (translator) — Faisal Rong Jasusi. An Angika adaptation of an Urdu children's novel. The original author and publication details are not clearly identified in the material under review.

B. Angika Folklore, Literary History and Supporting Works

17. Gautam, Dr Suresh; Gautam, Dr Veena (eds) — Bharatiya Bal-Loksahitya Kosh. An edited encyclopaedic work concerning children's oral traditions in various Indian languages. The prior publication of some essays by Dr Amarendra is connected with this collection. Complete publication details are not available in the material under review.

18. Gautam, Dr Suresh; Gautam, Dr Veena (eds) — Bharatiya Lori-Sahitya Kosh. An edited encyclopaedic collection on Indian lullaby traditions. The material under review does not supply full publication details.

19. Jagpriya, Chandraprakash (ed.) — Angika Lokokti, Phekra Aro Bujhauval. A collection of Angika proverbs, proverbial expressions and riddles; an important source for the book's discussion of riddles. Publication details are not clearly supplied in the material under review.

20. Tiwari, Meena (ed.) — Chalo Khissa Ke Gaon. A collection of Angika folktales. The material under review does not clearly provide its year of publication or publisher.

21. Bhatt, Vanchha Anjan — Phuljhamar. A collection of Angika folktales. The material under review does not clearly provide its year of publication or publisher.

22. Kumari, Dr Shobha — Angika Sahitya ka Itihas. A historical study of the literary development and traditions of the Angika language. Publication details are not clearly given in the material under review.

23. Grierson, George Abraham — Linguistic Survey of India. A source for the classification of Angika/Chhika-Chhiki within the linguistic survey project published from 1903 onwards. The title is given in its Maithili form in the source bibliography.

24. The Siddhacharyas — Charyapada. An early collection of verses from the Buddhist Siddha tradition, cited in discussions of the emerging linguistic and literary traditions of eastern India, including Angika and Maithili.

C. Foundational Works of Indian Poetics and Epistemology

25. Anandavardhana — Dhvanyaloka. A foundational Sanskrit treatise on dhvani, suggestion and poetic meaning; the theoretical basis in this essay for analysing the sound patterns and suggestive meanings of children's songs and riddles.

26. Kuntaka — Vakroktijivita. A foundational Sanskrit treatise on oblique expression, the arrangement of phonemes, and expressiveness at the levels of word, sentence, episode and whole composition; used here to analyse the indirection of Angika riddles and children's poetry.

27. Gangesha Upadhyaya — Tattvachintamani. A major epistemological work of Navya-Nyaya and the philosophical foundation for analyses of valid cognition, inference, pervasion and processes of knowing.

D. Foundational Western Studies of Children's Literature — Titles Given in Maithili Form

28. Reynolds, Kimberley — Children's Literature: A Very Short Introduction. Oxford University Press, 2011. An introductory study concerned with oral tradition, the cultural initiation of successive generations, the history of children's literature and socialisation.

29. Ewers, Hans-Heino — Fundamental Concepts of Children's Literature Research. Routledge, 2009. A study of child-appropriateness, classification, literary communication and fundamental concepts in the study of children's literature.

21. The Critical Theory of Maithili Children's Novels

Abstract

A Detailed Critical Examination of Gajendra Thakur's Thirty-Seven Children's Novels (in the Light of Indian and Western Theories of Children's-Literature Criticism). Introduction: A Critical Perspective on Children's Literature and These Thirty-Seven Books

Keywords: children · novels · critical theory · Maithili

A Detailed Critical Examination of Gajendra Thakur's Thirty-Seven Children's Novels

(In the Light of Indian and Western Theories of Children's-Literature Criticism)

Introduction: A Critical Perspective on Children's Literature and These Thirty-Seven Books

This book presents detailed critical readings of thirty-seven Maithili children's novels written by Gajendra Thakur. These thirty-seven books do not constitute a miscellaneous assortment: they form a deliberately designed architecture of writing for children, bringing together original contemporary children's fiction, alphabet instruction, animal tales, tales of wit, fairy tales, Mithila's heroic folk epics, love legends, devotional legends, biographies of folk deities, folk theatre, and narratives centred on music—all under one roof. Their criticism, therefore, cannot be undertaken as a collection of disconnected reviews. The examination of one book draws another into view, just as the ghats of a single pond are connected beneath the surface of the water. The arrangement of the present volume of criticism attempts to grasp precisely that network of relationships.

Two principal standards of criticism have been adopted, Indian and Western, not as opposing systems but as complementary ones. On the Indian side stands, first, the theory of rasa. In the language of Bharata Muni's Natyashastra, the aim of children's literature may be described as the realisation of rasa: a proportionate combination, for young readers, of heroism (vira), wonder (adbhuta), humour (hasya), pathos (karuna), and parental tenderness (vatsalya). In this collection, the heroic rasa reaches its summit in Dina-Bhadri and Chhechhan; pathos in Mahua Ghatwarin and Moti Dai; wonder in Raja Ansari and Bihula; humour in Murkhadhiraj and Untani; and tenderness in Bal Guru and Varnamala Shiksha. The second Indian criterion is Kshemendra's principle of aucitya, or appropriateness. How fully should an incident be told to children? At what

point should the narrative 'lower its eyes'? Questions of this kind are central to the author's editorial judgement throughout the thirty-seven works and will recur in almost every review. The third criterion is the frame-story tradition of the Panchatantra and Hitopadesha: a story within a story, with ethical instruction conveyed through narrative. The introductory and concluding conversations between Ba and Om that frame Tarhari Me Parilok and Untani renew Vishnu Sharma's ancient narrative technique in Maithili. The fourth criterion is the theory of dhvani: the suggested significance of a children's story, a meaning that may become apparent to a child immediately and to an adult only later.

Five major instruments are drawn from Western criticism. First is Vladimir Propp's morphology of the folktale: narrative functions such as interdiction and its violation, the donor figure, the magical agent, the difficult task, and the exposure of a false hero. In books such as Raja Ansari, Raja Dholan, and Brahman Aa Thakurak Katha these functions appear with almost textbook clarity. Second is the Aarne–Thompson–Uther (ATU) index of tale types. Where a Maithili tale corresponds to an international tale pattern—as Murkhadhiraj does to ATU 1696, Kauwa Aa Phuddi to the cumulative-tale category, or the petrified friend in Brahman Aa Thakurak Katha to ATU 516—the correspondence is noted, placing Maithili children's literature in a worldwide context. Third is Bruno Bettelheim's psychoanalytic argument in The Uses of Enchantment: the dark passages of fairy tales externalise children's internal fears and help them work through those fears. Death, witches, and betrayal should therefore not be removed wholesale from children's narratives; it is their presentation that must be handled with care. Fourth is Maria Nikolajeva's question of aetonormativity: the balance between adult authority and children's agency. A distinctive feature of this collection is that children repeatedly become decisive agents—Astha, Om, Mansha, the boy of Bagiyak Gachh, Battu, and Ansari's younger son. Fifth is Perry Nodelman's theory of picture books: the panels identified as 'pictures' in each book give narrative movement a visual rhythm, participating in the double reading of words and images that Nodelman explores in Words about Pictures. Peter Hunt's child-centred approach, J. R. R. Tolkien's 'eucatastrophe' (the unexpected grace of a happy ending), Jack Zipes's discussion of socialisation, and John Stephens's analysis of ideology are also brought in wherever they are pertinent.

There is a third standard, neither exclusively Indian nor Western: the Videha Parallel Literature Movement's own principle of placing the knowledge of the people on a level with the classical treatises. The most revolutionary feature of the collection is its company of protagonists: the Musahar heroes Dina and Bhadri; the Dusadh figures Salhes and Chuharmal; Chhechhan the Dom; Gariban the Dhobi; Lalmain the

Chamar; Amarsingh and Gango the Mallahs; and Raghuni the Marar. These are the folk-deity figures whom elite literature pushed to the margins for centuries. Retelling their legends for children is not mere entertainment. It democratises the literary world, inscribing on the next generation's mental map not only admirable lines of verse but also communities whose lives deserve recognition.

The reviews are arranged in four parts. Part One treats modern original stories for children and instructional narratives (reviews 1–4); Part Two covers tales, animal stories, trickster stories, and wonder tales (reviews 5–15); Part Three concerns heroic and romantic folk legends (reviews 16–26); and Part Four examines devotion, folk deities, ritual, and artistic narratives (reviews 27–37). Five principles are observed in each review: a brief account of the plot; an analysis of rasa and aucitya from Indian perspectives; an examination of structure and psychology from Western perspectives; an assessment of suitability for children; and, finally, intertextual links with the other books in the collection. To avoid unnecessary repetition, arguments established fully in one review are subsequently referred to more briefly. The reviews may now begin.

Part One: Modern Original Children's Fiction and Instructional Tales

1. Tarhari Me Parilok: Beyond the Tree Hollow—Maithili's First Dystopia for Children

The opening book of the collection is its most modern in both technique and boldness. Ba tells Om a story. Ten-year-old Astha enters a hollow in a densely branching tree in Channa Gachhi and tumbles into a radiant 'fairyland', where she meets displaced travellers from eight continents: African turaco birds, mamba snakes, Australian kookaburras, Eskimos, penguins, and others. From the surface, the land is beautiful: flowerbeds of seven colours, smooth frictionless roads, and creatures that all speak human language. But Astha's observant, questioning eyes lift the veils one by one. No wind blows here; no leaf stirs. Citizens have numbers instead of names (Vansapto *99995745*). Nobody has seen the queen. Beyond the rampart, a desert has been created by repeatedly dumping waste at the queen's command. In the end it emerges that fairyland is a counterfeit kingdom run by deranged scientists, while in the desert dismissed as the 'dark world', a king of walking plants is operating an alternative place of renewal. There are breath, hunger, and a heart there. Using the power of dreams, Astha has all eight hollows sealed and returns home.

From a Western perspective, this book stands at the meeting point of three traditions. Falling through the tree hollow is a Maithili echo of Alice's descent into the rabbit hole in Lewis Carroll: weightless falling, the strange flow of time, and the disappearance of up and down. But Alice's

'nonsense' gradually turns here into a children's dystopia reminiscent of Lois Lowry's The Giver: a colour-coded division of labour, numbers in place of names, invisible authority, and an 'other' cast beyond the boundary of a supposedly perfect world. The third tradition is ecological fiction: a desert made of waste, and walking trees that plant a forest on mounds resembling the backs of whales. Nature is not the villain here but the exiled protagonist. In Tzvetan Todorov's vocabulary, the narrative begins in the 'marvellous' and ends near science fiction through an explanatory reversal—fairyland proves to be the scientists' deception. This crossing of genres has considerable educational value for the young reader. By Nikolajeva's measure of aetonormativity, the book scores exceptionally well: the greatest power in the entire world, the ability to make dreams come true, belongs to a ten-year-old girl. She uses that power not for war but for negotiation and the closing of doors: 'If something can be settled through friendship, what need is there for a quarrel?' This is the seed statement of the collection's ethics of peace. Its echo will be heard in Om's words of forgiveness in Bal Guru (review 2).

From an Indian perspective, adbhuta rasa predominates, but a trace of shanta, tranquillity, follows close behind it. The line on the last page about a 'faint sound' coming from within the sealed hollow is an excellent example of dhvani. Its literal meaning is simply a closed door; its suggested meaning is that the answer to a question can never be shut away for ever. Astha's scientific curiosity about stomata and chloroplasts is a contemporary form of the questioning pupil of the Upanishadic tradition: to ask questions is not disobedience but a form of learning. In terms of aucitya, the author keeps dystopian cruelty at the level of suggestion—the laboratory of the orange line, the ominous implication of 'we need such intelligent people'—giving young readers unease rather than terror. And unease is the mother of thought. The opening and conclusion in which Ba speaks with Om modernise the Panchatantra's frame-story device. Within that frame, the lamp's going out and the shimmering white sky of fairyland form a finely worked parallel. The frame will open again in Untani (review 4), while Om himself becomes the protagonist of Bal Guru. Together the three books form an internal ring within the architecture of the collection.

2. Bal Guru: A Five-Year-Old's Philosophy of Forgiveness

A residential complex in Delhi: Mithila on the third floor (Om's home), Punjab in the block opposite (Mansha's home), and a teenage girl from Odisha, Mahua, looking after Mansha. In the grassy park, Om and Mansha have shared a friendship for four years. Then comes the newly arrived Susen, an altercation, the arrow of the word 'dirty', and Mansha's roar: 'Om is my friend! Anyone who calls him dirty is dirty himself!' Then

comes Om's reply, the heart of the book: 'He doesn't know me. He's new here. That's why he called me dirty. Once he gets to know us, do you think he'll still call me dirty?' That is the whole story. Yet within this small compass, the writer creates something rare in children's literature: what may be called realistic fiction. There is no fairy, no magic, no distant past —only today's metropolis and today's multilingual India.

Western criticism would place the book within literature about 'peer aggression', or bullying, but would immediately notice a difference: the two conventional resolutions in Western bullying stories—adult intervention and retaliation—are both rejected. A child offers the resolution himself, through cognitive reframing. The cause of the aggressor's behaviour is understood not as wickedness but as unfamiliarity. In the language of developmental psychology, this is an extraordinary demonstration of 'theory of mind': a child younger than five shapes his response by imagining another person's mental state. From Nikolajeva's perspective, the reversal of power operates on two levels. The child teaches the adults (his mother herself asks, 'Who is the teacher and who is the pupil?'), while the moral centre of the narrative is balanced between the sexes: Om is the teacher of forgiveness, Mansha of courage. The author explicitly says, 'One teaches forgiveness, one teaches courage. Together they make the whole lesson.' The arrangement answers Zipes's warning that children's literature often assigns patience to girls and bravery to boys. Here the pattern is reversed.

From the Indian perspective, this is a narrative of the courage of forgiveness, a child's commentary on 'kshama virasya bhushanam'—forgiveness is the ornament of the brave. In terms of rasa, vatsalya predominates, but it flows in three streams: the birth mother, Mahua who nurtures and cares, and the mother who learns. 'There were three mothers there that evening.' Mahua is among the collection's subtlest social observations: she is a child herself, yet she looks after another child. Her unfinished Odia song—'At the mention of her village, her throat filled and the song stopped'—weaves the pain of migrant child labour into the narrative without a speech about it. At the end, the line 'Where someone knows you by name, a song does not catch in your throat' extends to Mahua the philosophy of recognition that Om had applied to Susen. Intertextually, Om's principle of forgiveness is paired with Astha's principle of negotiation in Tarhari Me Parilok. Its contradictory dialogue with the folk-epic section is also interesting: in Dina-Bhadri (16) and Miran Saheb (23), humiliation and murder are answered by revenge; Bal Guru proposes an alternative ethic from within the same tradition. The author sets both before the reader without pronouncing a verdict. That is the collection's internal dialectic, to be considered again in the epilogue.

3. Varnamala Shiksha: Ankita—An Innovative Journey through the Alphabet

This is the collection's only entirely instructional narrative, a didactic text transparent about its declared purpose. Ankita and her father take an evening walk, and every chapter is woven from words belonging to a particular class of letters in the Maithili alphabet: beginning with 'akadārūṇ', 'akachchh', 'aginavān', and 'akkhaj' under the vowel a; passing through 'ogarbāh', 'kaṛekamān', 'kadbā', and 'kamarsāri' in the ka series; and reaching 'rajanī', 'lassā', and 'harṣ' in the later ya-to-ha series. Each chapter ends with questions and answers.

In the history of Western educational practice, its lineage resembles the abecedarium, or alphabet-book tradition, from Comenius's Orbis Pictus to contemporary alphabet books. Yet the work possesses two original features. First, the letters appear not in a pictured inventory but in the flow of a story. Words are encountered in context, which accords with modern language-acquisition theory's argument that vocabulary develops through use and context rather than through lists. Second, the end-of-chapter questions are a practical form of Vygotsky's 'zone of proximal development': what the child has just heard in narrative form returns immediately as questions to consolidate memory. The author's note to teachers—'How many times a story should be told depends on the child's capacity'—recognises the principle of individual pacing, now described as 'differentiated instruction'. Most valuable of all, the selected words are not modern, standardised vocabulary cast in the shadow of Hindi; they are distinctly Maithili folk words—'uṛkussī', 'ukāpataṅg', 'ṭābhnebok', and 'ḍihbār'. Under the pretext of an alphabet lesson, the book thus becomes a lexicon conserving a disappearing vocabulary. In an age of language loss, a primer for children in a minority language is not simply teaching: it is resistance. What Zipes calls literature's 'socialising function' operates here at the level of linguistic survival.

From an Indian perspective, this book gives narrative form to the initiation into writing, the aksharabhyasa rite. The image of the 'aksharamushtika' appearing in the introductory frame of Tarhari Me Parilok—the small fingers of Om enclosed by Ba's wrinkled fingers, 'like ink inside a pen'—finds its systematic course of study here. Read together, the two books show that initiation into letters belongs to an initiation into affection. Vatsalya assumes an intimate, domestic form: tired feet, Ankita's insistence on a red stick, and the promise of 'fresh bread'. Her father's explanation, 'I was walking quickly so that you could arrive sooner and rest', reveals the love concealed behind discipline and gives young readers a new lens through which to read parental 'strictness'. A limitation must also be observed. Some repetitions in the numbering of chapters

(Chapter 3 occurs in two places) and the brevity of the later letter groups suggest that the experiment remains in its seed stage. In the teacher's note, the author himself invites parents and teachers to develop it further. In the architecture of the collection, the book is a bridge: on one side is modern narrative; on the other, the treasury of folk words whose living use is found in the subsequent section on folk epics.

4. Untani: The Damage Done by Imitation and the Discipline of Humour

The Ba–Om frame opens once again. This time Om's request is explicit: 'I want a funny story, not a frightening one!' Ba takes her story from the fields of Haryana. A leaf of a jal tree is stuck in a female camel's throat. A passer-by asks four questions, slaps the camel's neck and dislodges the leaf, then departs saying, 'I am a doctor.' The farmer concludes that this is all there is to medicine. Shouting 'I am a doctor' from village to village, he applies the same questionnaire to a sick old woman ('Had the old woman fallen on her right side? … Had she been eating the leaves of a jal tree?') and strikes her in the same way. The old woman dies. He must help carry her corpse, and when he demands his fee, he is beaten. In the next village the sole lesson he has learned is: 'I will certainly treat the patient, but I will not help carry the corpse!'

In the study of tale types, this belongs to the internationally familiar family of stories about foolish imitation, a group extending from the German Doctor Know-All to Indian tales of imitative jackals, in which someone copies the outward appearance of success without possessing the knowledge behind it. Henri Bergson's theory of laughter applies almost like a textbook example: comedy arises when mechanical repetition displaces living judgement. The farmer repeats his questionnaire mechanically, without noticing that the circumstances have changed. The author's boldness, however, lies in allowing laughter to collide with death in mid-story. The old woman's death sends a chill through the comic narrative, raising it above the ordinary amusing tale into a children's version of dark comedy. In Bettelheim's terms, this death is not necessarily inappropriate: children need to understand that foolishness is not harmless and that others may have to pay its price. Applying aucitya, the author confines the death to a single sentence—'The old woman died then and there'—and avoids lingering over grief. This is the restraint of the adaptation for children, evident repeatedly elsewhere in the collection (Amar Baba, review 24; Bagiyak Gachh, review 5).

The book's true marvel lies in its frame. When the story ends, Ba states the moral plainly ('Before learning to do anything, one must understand its essence; imitation alone is not enough'). This is ethical instruction in the manner of the Panchatantra's framed tales. But what follows goes beyond

the conventional moral story. Om asks what Ba means by 'the story from our own direction', and Ba avoids answering: 'I thought you would be coming anyway, so I didn't tell it!' The story closes with its incompleteness, and the child falls asleep laughing. What Nodelman calls the 'hidden adult' in children's literature—the adult standing behind the child reader, selecting and omitting elements of a story—appears here as a character. Ba herself is the editor who decides what to say and what to leave unsaid. Architecturally, this book is the companion to Tarhari Me Parilok. There Ba opened the door to wonder; here she opens the door to humour. Across the two, the tale of the false doctor converses directly with the fraudulent holy man of Gonu Jha Aa Das Thop Baba (review 11). There genuine intelligence exposes false erudition; here false learning exposes itself. Together they complete the collection's lesson in authenticity: knowledge comes from understanding, not from putting on a show.

Part Two: Narrative Tales, Animal Stories, Wit and Wonder Tales

5. Bagiyak Gachh: The Grammar of a Trickster Tale and Its Dark Corner

The clever son of a widowed woman plants a garden, an extraordinary tree grows in it, and the tree attracts the attention of an old witch. With three pretexts—'hathain', 'mathain', and 'khonchhain'—she persuades the boy to bend down and shuts him in a sack. When she falls asleep, he fills the sack with earth, stones, and thorns and escapes. A second time he is deceived by an oath sworn by the disguised witch. In the end he saves himself by trapping the witch's daughter in a trick involving a mortar and pestle. A cat's warning, 'Go and eat your own daughter', reveals what has happened, and the witch's misdeeds return upon her own head.

This narrative is a Maithili member of the familiar international tale-type family in which a witch puts a child in a sack or bag and takes the child home, only for the child to escape repeatedly through ingenuity (the ATU 327 family, especially 327C). Propp's sequence of functions unfolds with remarkable clarity: interdiction (the mother warns against deceivers), violation (the boy trusts an oath), abduction, counteraction, and punishment. Bettelheim interprets stories of this family as dramatisations of the child's primal fear of 'being swallowed'. The witch's craving for meat is that fear embodied, while the child's repeated escapes rehearse the victory of intelligence over it. Notice that the boy is deceived twice. The author does not present cleverness as infallible: error, a repeated error, and only then learning. This error-tolerant learning curve is exemplary from the standpoint of child psychology because it teaches alertness rather than perfection.

Judged by the principle of aucitya, this book is a manifesto of the collection's editorial policy. At the moment in Chapter Eight when the boy does something to the witch's daughter that is brutal in the original folktale, the author explicitly says, 'This was the darkest moment of the tale, and the tale will not dwell on it.' In Chapter Ten comes another declaration: 'The tale will not describe this tragic event in detail.' This is a technique of narrative averting or withholding: the event is not denied, but it is left undescribed. Young readers know that something terrible has happened, yet the image is entrusted to their imagination—and imagination generally produces images only as far as its bearer can endure. This middle path between Bettelheim and modern critiques of the 'sanitisation' of fairy tales is the author's signature technique throughout the collection (compare Amar Baba, 24; Moti Saeri, 26; and Untani, 4). In terms of rasa, the mixture of hasya and bhayanaka, described in the book's own subtitle as 'humorous and thrilling', reaches a peak in the episode involving urination upon the witch's head: fear is released through laughter. This is a classically intelligible treatment of the rasa of terror in a children's story. The author himself establishes the boy's kinship with Gonu Jha ('The boy belonged to Gonu Jha's own original lineage'). Gonu Jha (11) is his adult counterpart, Battu (6) his animal counterpart, and Murkhadhiraj (9) his inverted shadow. In the last of these we will see what happens when imitation replaces intelligence and the same narrative grammar is turned upside down.

6. Battu: The Power of Speech in the Weak

Warned by his mother, a four-month-old male kid runs into the forest overnight to escape sacrifice during Durga Puja. Two or three years later, he has grown into Battu, with an imposing beard and horns. When he confronts a tiger, he frightens it away through extravagant poetic boasting ('I played with seven lions … unless there are ten tigers, I do not even bother to break my fast'). A jackal ties his legs to the tiger's and brings it back. Battu then unleashes his final weapon: 'I told you to bring me two tigers, and you have brought only one?' The tiger runs, and the tethered jackal is dragged to his death.

The story belongs to an ancient Indian animal-tale pattern in which a weak animal defeats a predator through the power of language: the family of jackal-and-lion stories in the Panchatantra, with worldwide forms ranging from The Brave Little Tailor to Tibetan and Indian tales of the tiger and the goat. Its central philosophical proposition is revolutionary for a young reader: reality is not exhausted by physical bodies; one layer of reality is made through language. The tiger does not flee from Battu's body but from Battu's words. What modern philosophy of language would call a 'performative utterance' takes place here in the middle of a forest. The

author is also careful that this power of boasting should not be understood as unethical. Battu's untruth is a lie told in self-defence. The story's distribution of punishment is unambiguous: it is not the tiger who is punished but the jackal, because the jackal's deception was aggressive, whereas Battu's was defensive. 'The jackal fell victim to his own cunning': this poetic justice is the narrative's moral backbone.

In terms of rasa, this is a rare combination of vira and hasya, which one might call 'heroism of speech'. Bettelheim allows a still deeper reading. At the opening hangs the shadow of sacrifice: the adults of the household are negotiating to sell their own child. It touches one of childhood's deepest fears: 'What if those who are supposed to protect me abandon me?' The narrative answers on two levels. The mother gives the warning (maternal protection), but the child must survive by his own power (self-reliance). From home to forest and from forest to self-sufficiency: this arc of exile and maturation is a distinctly folk version of the Western coming-of-age pattern. Intertextually, the question raised by the child about sacrifice during Durga Puja anticipates, in miniature, the questions about the relation between humans and divinity in Gariban Baba (28) and Moti Dai (27). Battu's 'two tigers' trick is also the animal-story form of Gonu Jha's question weapon—'Where will you keep so many bamboos?' (11). In both narratives, victory depends not on possessing information but on managing it.

7. Kauwa Aa Phuddi: The Sorrowful End of a Cumulative Tale

During a famine, a crow and a phuddi bird decide to eat their own offspring. The crow's child is eaten; but when the phuddi's turn comes, the cunning bird sends the crow to the Ganges to wash his beak. The Ganges demands an earthen cup; the potter needs clay; the field requires a deer's horn; the deer demands a lion; the lion asks for a cow's milk; the cow wants grass; and the grass requires a sickle. When the crow finally reaches the blacksmith, he sings the entire chain as a song. The blacksmith offers two sickles, one black and one red. The crow grips the red-hot one in his beak, convulses, and dies.

This book demonstrates the collection's generic diversity. It is a pure cumulative tale (ATU 2030 category), part of the international genre of children's storytelling in which every link repeats all those before it, as in This Is the House That Jack Built. Its pedagogical value is well known: repetition trains memory, a lengthening list exercises the sense of sequence, and the crow's final song ('Brother blacksmith, give me a sickle; I shall cut the grass and feed the cow …') invites collective recitation by child listeners. This participatory moment of oral tradition is preserved even in the written version. Yet the author puts two serious elements inside this joyous form. The first is the opening famine, in which the birds decide

to eat their children. This is a merciless reality of folktale that the author leaves unsoftened in a single paragraph before proceeding. Memories of famine form part of Mithila's collective past (compare Raghuni Marar, 32, and Madhav Singh, 37, where scarcity propels the plot). Allowing an echo of that history to reach children is an early lesson in historical consciousness. The second is the sudden death at the end: the exact inverse of Tolkien's 'eucatastrophe', for which one might coin 'dyscatastrophe'. A long chain of effort is reduced to nothing by one wrong choice, the red sickle.

Here criticism must raise an honest question: is the ending too harsh for a child reader? The author's answer appears in the concluding chapter: the story 'makes children laugh and at the same time compels them to think'. Read through Bettelheim, the answer gains force. The crow dies not because of greed but because of unthinking obedience: he accepts every demand without questioning it. Nor is the phuddi's 'victory' truly a victory: her deception costs her friend his life. The story puts both extremes, blind innocence and cunning, in the dock, leaving the middle path of alert simplicity unstated. That space belongs to the child's own judgement. Intertextually, the phuddi's pretence of 'purification' (washing the beak in the Ganges) is an ironic foreshadowing of the greatness of the Ganges in the collection's devotional section (Bar Sukhsar, 34). There the Ganges bestows liberation; here the road to the Ganges leads to death. It is a moving demonstration of where the language of purity can lead when it falls into the hands of deceit.

8. Doki-Doka: A Folk Allegory of the Journey Through Separation

The extravagant love between Doka and Doki (a delay of seconds in bringing the stars is pardonable, but a delay of minutes is not) arouses the envy of a jackal and his mate. The jackal plants a doubt in Doki's mind ('It seems his heart has turned towards someone else'). Doka goes into the forest and does not return. A yogi foretells that a curse from a former birth is at work: if she abandons her faith, Doka will be lost, but he will be found on the seventh day. Doki then sets out in search of him. Refusing the egret's, the jackal's, the banyan tree's, and the elephant's invitations to 'stay for one night', she goes with a mouse, who leads her towards a palace while telling her a story. She forgets to respond to the story, crosses a tunnel, and, on the seventh night, the mouse puts his face into a bowl of halwa and dies. Amid Doki's lamenting song, the door opens: there stands Doka, carrying an axe.

This small book is the most dreamlike work in the collection, and its criticism should proceed not by the logic of ordinary reality but by dream logic. Its closest counterpart in Western narratology is the structure of the quest, in which obstacles are not material but temptations. Each invitation

to 'stay' is a test, and Doki's lament ('I left the egret, left the jackal, left the banyan tree; I left the strong elephant and took this mouse') is the poetic reckoning of those tests. Notice a subtle and courageous decision. Doki leaves the mighty elephant and chooses the frail mouse as her companion. In the grammar of a quest tale, the choice of a helper tests the protagonist's character, and Doki chooses humble companionship over the worship of strength. The sorrowful irony is that this very humble companion perishes in a moment of greed. The mouse's condition for telling his story ('Keep saying yes from time to time') is a story-within-a-story memorial to the listener's duty in oral storytelling. The listener's answering murmur, the hunkari, is the lifeblood of Mithila's storytelling culture; forgetting the response becomes the forgetting of the story itself. This metafictional moment quietly teaches the child reader that a story is the shared creation of speaker and listener.

From an Indian perspective, this is a child-accessible transformation of vipralambha-shringara, love in separation. The aspect of love that the folk tradition sings in the barahmasa and the songs of longing appears here as an animal allegory, and the allegory makes it bearable for a child. The jackal's seed of jealousy is a recurring motif across the collection. Compare Prithvipal's malicious insinuations (Munga and Jalim Singh, 19), the Chaudhary's envy (Raghuni Marar, 32), and the taluqdar's resentment (Raja Salhes, 17). The author repeatedly shows that the first instrument for breaking a relationship is not a weapon but a rumour. The numerical mystery of the 'seventh night' belongs to the temporal arithmetic of folktales, which renders waiting measurable. Endless waiting is unbearable to a child; waiting seven nights can become a game. In this way the story teaches patience without preaching patience.

9. Murkhadhiraj: An Inverted Tale of Cleverness and the Social Grammar of Humour

The exceptionally foolish son of a cowherd—who has even forgotten that he is married—sets off at his father's bidding to bring his bride home for the gauna ceremony. When puffed rice flies about, he says, 'Come, fly away,' and is beaten by birdcatchers. The phrase he is taught next, 'Come and be caught,' reaches the ears of thieves; 'May this happen in every house' is said in a cremation ground; and 'May such a thing happen in no house' is uttered at a wedding procession. Everywhere he is beaten, everywhere he receives a new formula, until he learns his last lesson: 'Say nothing.' Having become a silent son-in-law, he returns from his in-laws' house with his bride. When the sun causes the vermilion on her forehead to run, he takes it for a 'broken head' and exchanges his wife for a barber's goat, then the goat for a pumpkin. While his father laments, he says, 'Cook the pumpkin and keep the curry ready,' and goes off to play.

This tale is an almost pure Maithili instance of the international fool-tale type ATU 1696 ('What Should I Have Said?'): the worldwide pattern in which a fool utters, in each new situation, the expression learned in the preceding one. Bergson's theory of laughter appears here in its clearest form. Language, a living practice dependent on context, becomes in the fool's hands a context-free machine. Society tries to 'correct' this mechanical behaviour by beating him, but each correction generates a new mechanical rule. In this sense, the story is a laboratory of the philosophy of language for children. The young reader learns through laughter that the meaning of words resides not simply in the words but in the occasion on which they are spoken. A livelier elementary lesson in pragmatics would be hard to find. This is the precise opposite of Bagiyak Gachh (5) and Battu (6): there the protagonists read the situation and fashion their speech accordingly; here the protagonist memorises speech and collides with the situation. Together, these three books constitute a complete elementary course in the use of language.

Beneath the humour, however, lies an uncomfortable layer that criticism must not ignore: the chain of exchanges, wife–goat–pumpkin. Inside the comic tale-type, it is also an image of the objectification of women. The author's defence is that the story is told from the fool's viewpoint and that every exchange adds a fresh count to the indictment of his foolishness; the father's beating of his own head represents the reader's moral response within the story. Even so, for an adult mediator—a teacher or parent—this book is an occasion for discussion, not for laughter without a sting. That is precisely its strength. What John Stephens calls an 'ideological gap' in narrative is deliberately left open here. In terms of rasa this is a book of unmixed hasya, yet the father's lament in the last scene drops into that humour a touch of karuna, lending it the distinctive flavour of the Maithili comic tradition (Harimohan Jha comes readily to mind): laughter with a little tear at its edge.

10. Bhat-Bhatin: Riddle, Betrayal, and a Sister's Intelligence

Bhatin secretly loves a jewel-bearing venomous snake: she serves good food to the snake and only stale scraps to her husband, and at last commands the snake to kill him. Hidden in a shoe, the snake falls out when the shoe is shaken and dies at Bhat's hands. Mourning the snake, Bhatin cuts it into nine pieces and hides them in a bedstead, a low stool, oil, salt, woodwork, and her hair, contriving a deadly riddle. If Bhat cannot solve it, he must die by being thrown into the bhaksi, the furnace. Granted two days' reprieve, Bhat visits his sister. In a dharmashala, lamps speak to one another at night and disclose the secret. The sister then stipulates a counter-condition, solves Bhatin's riddle, and subjects her to the very punishment she devised.

The story joins two ancient streams of world folklore: the story family of the woman with a serpent lover and that of the lethal or 'neck' riddle, in which life hangs upon the answer to a question. The psychology of the riddle tale has particular value in children's literature. A riddle dramatises knowledge: one who knows survives. Here the source of knowledge is supernatural hearing, the conversation of lamps, which expresses folklore's deep conviction that truth is being spoken somewhere or other; what is needed is someone to listen. Talking lamps belong to the living world of objects in the Maithili household and courtyard, where the hearth, the rice-pounder, and the lamp are all imagined to possess a life of their own. For young readers, this animistic imagination is the natural language of children's thinking as described by Piaget: the story speaks in the child's own way of comprehending the world.

The moral centre of this book is the sister, an important figure in the collection's sequence of female agency. Alongside Mansha (2), Astha (1), Bihula (33), and Moti Saeri (26), she takes her place among women who seize the power to decide in a crisis. Notice her method: she neither weeps nor launches a direct assault; she reverses Bhatin's own rule of the game ('If you can solve the riddle …') and turns it against her. The defeat of a rule through the application of that very rule marks a sophisticated sense of justice. Judged by aucitya, the final punishment ('throwing into the bhaksi') retains the severity of the oral tale; the author disposes of it in a single sentence, without depiction—the same technique of narrative withholding (compare review 5). At a psychoanalytic level, the plot to murder the husband and the concealment of nine body parts do not reach the child's conscious awareness in all their implications, but the story's emotional message reaches it clearly: betrayal within the home is the most dangerous of betrayals, while a blood relation—the sister—is the last stronghold in a crisis. Intertextually, the ordinary habit of shaking out a shoe, which saves a life, exemplifies the collection's recurring principle that a small practice can provide great protection (compare Rohineya's practice of covering his ears, 14). The jewel of the jewel-bearing snake also connects directly with the serpent-jewel episode in Brahman Aa Thakurak Katha (12): in both, the jewel is an ambivalent symbol of greed and illumination.

11. Gonu Jha and Das Thop Baba: A Folk Hero of Rational Inquiry

Mithila is in the grip of drought. Following the king's public proclamation, Das Thop Baba appears, claiming, 'I performed penance in the Himalayas for a hundred years; a sacrifice will bring rain.' Returning from a visit to his in-laws, Gonu Jha becomes suspicious and, disguised as Bis Thop Baba, presents himself as a rival. Amid the absurd competing claims of 'Shri Shri 108 Bis Thop Baba', Gonu asks one piercing question: 'Will you prod the clouds with bamboo? Where will you store so much

bamboo?' The pretence collapses. The baba tries to escape on the pretext of relieving himself, but people tear away his false beard; Gonu removes his own false moustache and reveals who he is.

Gonu Jha is one of the perennial heroes of the Maithili popular imagination. Western criticism would place him in the international company of clever trickster figures: Birbal, Tenali Raman, Nasreddin Hodja, and the European Till Eulenspiegel. More important than Gonu's trickster identity in this story, however, is his method, which is almost a folk version of the scientific method: listen to the claim (a sacrifice will produce rain), ask for the mechanism of the claim (by what procedure?), examine the physical possibility of the answer (where would such enormous quantities of bamboo be kept?), and reach a judgement when the answer proves inconsistent. This series of questions is a Mithila version of what Carl Sagan calls 'baloney detection', and its value for child readers is immense. The story teaches that reverence and examination are not mutually exclusive. Gonu stands not against religion but against fraud. The author's fine distinction—the mockery of a charlatan's competition in the number of his 'thop' marks, and Gonu's own assumed disguise, which he voluntarily removes in the end—clarifies the ethical difference between hypocrisy and strategic disguise: a disguise is an instrument when used to uncover truth, but hypocrisy when used for self-glorification.

In terms of rasa the tale is pure hasya, yet the background—a people suffering from drought—provides a faint underlayer of karuna, and that underlayer sharpens the satire. Charlatans flourish especially where misfortune and hope form a heated marketplace. In this sense the story is the complete counterpoint to Madhav Singh Aa Amta Gam (37): both begin at the same point, Mithila's drought and the search for rain, but there an authentic discipline of musical knowledge brings the sky within reach, whereas here the pretence of asceticism is torn away along with a false beard. The pairing appears deliberate in the architecture of the collection: the line between knowledge and its performance, the very line separating the traveller and the imitative farmer in Untani (4). From Nikolajeva's perspective on authority, the interesting feature here is that royal power (the king) is credulous while intellectual authority (Gonu) is alert. This persistent pattern of the folktale simultaneously cultivates in young readers a healthy scepticism towards power and respect for intelligence.

12. Brahman Aa Thakurak Katha: A Confluence of Three Stories Within a Story, and the Stone of a Promise

A Brahmin of Debiganj takes a Thakur child with him on a journey to perform a Satyanarayan puja. The child stipulates that whenever he encounters something he cannot understand, the Brahmin must explain it.

Three sights on the road then open three narratives: the story of a queen who, overcome by shame and modesty, leaps into a river after the discovery of a woman's corpse weighted with sand; the story behind a goat being kicked, in which a treacherous friend uses a mantra of changing bodies to appropriate a king's body (until the intelligence of a fairy returns the parrot-king and imprisons the betrayer in the goat); and, behind the sight of an old woman being led to the gallows, the long tale of the maiden Nagavati, a mad prince, and a minister's son. The last includes twenty-five dangers foretold by fate, a friend who turns to stone as he discloses the secrets, and his restoration to life through contact with the blood of a newborn child.

In its structure, this is the most ambitious book in the collection: a frame narrative, a narrative casket containing stories within stories, whose Indian genealogy reaches back through the Panchatantra, Vetala-Panchavimshati, and Kathasaritsagara. The journey is the frame, curiosity the key, and each declaration of 'I do not understand' opens the lock on another tale. Pedagogically, this device is invaluable. The child's 'why?' is not scolded here but rewarded with a story; questioning itself fuels the narrative mechanism, as Astha's questions did in Tarhari Me Parilok (1). The stone episode of the third tale is a Maithili form of the enduring international tale type ATU 516 ('Faithful John'): the servant who knows how to protect his master turns to stone as he divulges the secret and is revived with a child's blood. Its line-by-line resemblance to 'Faithful John' in the Grimm collection testifies to the world citizenship of Maithili's treasury of tales. In Propp's vocabulary the complete cycle is present: interdiction (do not reveal the secret), violation (the king's insistence), punishment (petrification), and restitution (the infant's blood). The moral burden, however, is reversed: the prohibition is broken not out of selfishness but from fear that the friend will be hanged, and so the narrative both punishes and delivers him.

From an Indian perspective the central rasa of the book is adbhuta, wonder. But what emerges from the conjunction of the three tales is an inquiry into speech and the keeping of one's word. In the first tale, shame outweighs speech (the queen leaps into the river); in the second, the misuse of an utterance—a mantra—brings destruction; in the third, protecting one's word turns a man to stone, and friendship makes that stone human again. A child listener who hears all three will arrive at a conclusion not through instruction but through triangular comparison: a refined form of the Hitopadesha's method of teaching ethics by means of stories. A critical qualification is necessary. The density of the third narrative—the old woman, the mad prince, abduction, the wedding party, and the twenty-five dangers—may be too heavy for a young reader in a single sitting. This is a book that calls for reading in stages, at successive stopping places like

the travelling pair themselves; that is its natural mode of use. Intertextually, the reinterpretation of the hanged old woman's supposed 'crime' (the condemned woman turns out, when her story is heard, to be intelligent) touches the collection's recurring problem of justice: the distance between what seems evident and what is true. The same question will recur in the false discovery of a necklace in Raja Salhes (17) and the delicate accusation of dishonour in Naika Banijara (21).

13. Raja Ansari: The Language of Dreams and the Discipline of Not Looking Back

King Ansari dreams of diamonds and pearls cascading inside his house, which everyone gathers up and eats like tender mango blossoms. His youngest son promises, 'I shall make it come true.' Separated from his brothers in the forest, the boy falls into a well after following a traveller's directions. Through his service to the yogi Bhairavananda he earns a boon, becomes a parrot, and sets out across seven seas to fetch the fruit of immortality. On the first attempt he turns to look back when a fairy calls, 'Turn and look', and dies; revived by the yogi's matted locks, he succeeds on his second attempt without looking back. He then encounters three fairy sisters in a grove of kalam trees. Finally comes the yogi's extraordinary command: take a knife to the throats of all three fairies and to your own throat at the same moment. There appear trees of gold, stems of silver, and falling pearls. At home the king sees merely 'three women' and calls his son a fool. Before the assembled town the son repeats the act, and the dream becomes reality.

This is the collection's purest wonder tale, filling almost every place in Propp's inventory of narrative functions: lack (the unrealised dream), departure, the donor (the yogi), a difficult task, interdiction ('Do not look back'), violation, death and revival, and a transformative conclusion. The prohibition against looking back is a deep motif of world mythology, extending from Orpheus and Eurydice to Lot's wife. Its psychological meaning reaches the young reader immediately: certain tasks demand such concentration that even a glance back towards the call of doubt, temptation, or the past can prove fatal. The boy fails the first time and succeeds the second. This repetition accompanied by correction (compare Bagiyak Gachh, 5) is a persistent feature of the collection's philosophy of learning. The final knife episode, whose logic the tale deliberately leaves unexplained, is the high point of the dream logic of wonder tales: an action resembling sacrifice, even directed towards one's own neck, opens the door to transformation. Leaving the burden of interpretation to the reader is the author's bold decision about aucitya, for an explanation would turn magic into a set of rules.

A second layer of the story is an interpretation of the meaning of dreams. The king takes the dream as a literal thing (tree equals tree); his son understands it as a relational truth (tree equals prosperity brought forth through the help of the fairies). The irony is that the child who is called a 'fool' proves literate in the language of dreams. The dialogue with Tarhari Me Parilok (1) is direct: there the dream becomes mechanically true and is politically misused; here the dream becomes true through labour, service, and obedience to a prohibition. Together the books offer children two lessons about dreaming: a dream is a power, and the character of power depends on the path by which it is pursued. In the language of rasa, the dominant wonder is tinged with parental tenderness (the father's anxiety and the son's promise), culminating in the spectacle of collective amazement as the whole town gathers up the falling blossoms. The folktale's happy ending is always communal rather than purely individual; this principle will recur in Bihula (33) and Madhav Singh (37).

14. Daku Rohineya: The Power of a Single Sentence—A Children's Jewel from the Jain Narrative Tradition

Magadha is ruled by Bimbisara, and the bandit Rohineya inspires fear. Yet he robs the rich and shares the spoils with the poor, and the people consequently protect him. His dying father, Lauhakhura, gives a command: never listen to Mahavira's sermons. During minister Abhayakumara's five-day vow to apprehend him, Rohineya boldly robs the royal palace. On the road, as he passes a place where a sermon is being delivered, he covers his ears; but a thorn pierces his foot, and while removing it he happens to hear one sentence: gods do not sweat, their garlands do not fade, their feet do not touch the earth, and their eyelids do not blink. Apprehended, Rohineya tries to save himself by posing as 'Durga the farmer'. Abhayakumara gives him wine and stages a false heaven, complete with gandharvas, apsaras, Indra's messengers, and a demand that he confess his sins. But Rohineya notices that these 'gods' are sweating, their garlands have wilted, and their feet rest on the ground. Armed with the single sentence he had overheard, he detects the deception and recounts only his meritorious deeds. When granted a promise of immunity, he tells the whole truth, renounces his wealth, and asks to be initiated by the very Mahavira whose one sentence saved his life.

This book is unique in genre within the collection. It is not a Mithila folk epic but a Maithili children's adaptation of a celebrated narrative from Jain literature (the Avashyaka-Churni and later narrative-compendium traditions). Its inclusion extends the collection's cultural horizon to the ancient shared geography of Magadha and Videha. The intellectual centre of the story is a jewel of logic: a single particle of prohibited knowledge may prove decisive. The father forbids the sermon as a source of 'ruin', but

one sentence of that sermon saves his son's life. The prohibition refutes itself. Western criticism would recognise here an early form of the 'epistemic thriller': the pleasure of a detective narrative in which victory comes not through strength but through observation and inference. Rohineya reads the sweating bodies and faded garlands of the sham heaven's 'gods' as a detective reads clues. Opposite him stands Abhayakumara, inheritor of the tradition of ministerial intelligence extending through the moral tales from Chanakya to Abhayakumara. This contest of two minds—one arranging deception, the other exposing it—is as exciting for a child as a game of chess, without a single drop of blood being spilled.

The moral architecture is subtle. Rohineya's 'Robin Hood' character—taking from the rich and giving to the poor—inclines the tale towards sympathy for him; nevertheless, the narrative secures his liberation not through a vindication of banditry but through its renunciation. The distinction between sympathy and approval is a measure of ideologically attentive children's literature. The transformation is convincing because it arises not from a miracle but from gratitude: 'I shall seek initiation from the teacher whose words saved my life.' Intertextually, the exposure of the counterfeit heaven is a state-sponsored variation on Gonu Jha's exposure of a charlatan (11). There real intelligence detects a false holy man; here genuine scriptural speech detects a false heaven. The father's command of prohibition is also the philosophical summit of the interdiction function in Battu (6) and Raja Ansari (13). Throughout the collection an interdiction sometimes protects, sometimes tests, and here proves false in itself. Excitement without violence, a plot governed by reasoning, and inward transformation make this the collection's most intellectual work.

15. Raja Dholan: The Epic of Curses, Concealment, and Letters

King Daksha of Garh Nariyal stubbornly buys cotton on the principle of purchasing what was not for sale, and the fortune of his kingdom takes offence. Impoverished, he goes to Garh Pingal to work as a horse attendant. Children are born on the same day in the two royal households, and, under the astrological necessity of a 'marriage on the sixth night', the newborn girl Madhuvan is married to Dholan, the horse attendant's newborn son. On the return journey, a tiger is killed and the tigress pronounces a curse: 'I shall make your son's bride a widow.' Terrified, the father buries the secret: a buffalo in a pit, his son in a gardener woman's flower garden, and the memory of the marriage in silence. Meanwhile, the grown Madhuvan distributes food and alms in a twelve-year sadavrat on the banks of the Jamuna, searching for her husband. A trader's letter is burned by the witches Hareba and Pareba; a parrot's letter is cast into the fire by the gardener woman. On the third attempt, a holy man carrying

ganja, bhang, and opium breaks through the magic with an enchanting flute and delivers the letter to Dholan. Questioned at sword-point, the father confesses. The buffalo, now afflicted with worms, is rescued, the tigress is killed, and Dholan makes himself known at his in-laws' home through the havoc he wreaks in the flower garden. At last come the palanquin, the ceremonial departure of the bride, and kingship.

This is the collection's most intricate wonder epic, and communication is the key to its criticism. The whole epic is, in fact, the story of three letters. The curse forbids information, the father buries it, the witches burn it, and deliverance occurs at the moment information finally arrives. Without consciously being taught the lesson, the child reader learns that a large part of family suffering arises less from conspiracy than from concealment. The father's silence was intended as 'protection', but its cost was the buffalo's imprisonment for years, the son's loss of identity, and the daughter-in-law's twelve-year wait. In Propp's terms, the tale consists of two cycles across two generations: the father's (transgression, downfall, exile) and the son's (ignorance, discovery, redress). The son succeeds precisely where the father failed: the father killed the tiger and incurred the curse, the son kills the tigress and lifts it; the father concealed the secret, the son brings it to light. This pattern of correction across generations (compare Rohineya, 14, who reverses his father's prohibition) expresses the collection's deep optimism: children need not remain prisoners of their parents' mistakes.

The position of women here particularly demands criticism. Madhuvan is not a heroine who merely waits. By establishing the sadavrat she creates a public centre for gathering information (the same strategy is employed by the fairy in Brahman Aa Thakurak Katha, 12). Her attempts through three different means of communication—a trader, a parrot, and a holy man—display strategic patience. Women stand on the opposing side as well, in the pair of witches Hareba and Pareba; the tale therefore distinguishes its allies from its enemies not by gender but by intention. The episode of the buffalo is one of the most moving expressions of compassion towards animals in the collection: an innocent creature's imprisonment over many years and the rescue of its worm-infested body. No book of sermons could give young readers the lesson in sympathy that they receive here. In rasa terms, this long combination of wonder and pathos finally comes to rest in shanta, tranquillity. The transformation of a 'servant's son' into a king also belongs to the collection's egalitarian undertone, which will sound fully in the folk-epic section, from Dina-Bhadri to Chhechhan.

Part Three: Heroic and Romantic Folk Epics

16. Dina-Bhadri: Two Sons of the Proverbial Soil — The Summit of the Tragic Heroic Epic

Dina and Bhadri, Musahar brothers from Jogiyanagar, wield spades weighing five maunds each, clear a bigha of land in a day, and possess righteousness alongside strength. Kanak Singh, the landlord of Janjar, tries to turn them into his 'oxen' and flees after being beaten. His wife Budhni performs austerities at Salhes's shrine and asks for a boon: 'The lives of Dina and Bhadri.' Bound by his promise, Salhes summons his own beloved heroes to the Katai forest through a dream. Crying 'Victory to King Salhes,' Dina defeats the tiger Khunima in wrestling, but a tigress disguised as a bagra kills both brothers through deceit. A succession of marvels follows: the spirits of the brothers, seated on a weighing pan made of arhar stalks, outweigh the contents of an entire shop; they serve food as attendants at a shraddha feast; the sign of the hansa; and their mother's milk bursting through seven layers of cloth. Then comes the killing of one hundred and fifty oppressors in the Morang region, Budhni's end, and Salhes's penitential promise: 'Wherever I am worshipped, you too shall be worshipped.'

This book is the cornerstone of the heroic-epic section of the collection and a child's gateway into the tradition of Maithili folk epics. In the vocabulary of Western tragic poetics, this is a tragedy in its pure form, but with one decisive difference from the Greek pattern: the hero has no 'tragic flaw.' The fault lies in the system—in the mechanics of fidelity to a promise, which makes even a deity an instrument of injustice. Salhes's moral dilemma ('If he breaks his word, divinity is broken; if he keeps his word, justice is broken') presents the young reader, perhaps for the first time, with the question whether rules and justice are always the same. This is an ascent towards the stage of moral development described by Kohlberg at which a child moves beyond obedience to rules and begins to assess their justice. As a counterweight to the tragedy, the folk tradition offers its own 'eucatastrophe': another turn of justice beyond death, through the balance, the milk, the slaying of a hundred and fifty oppressors, and a share in worship. What Tolkien calls the sudden grace of a happy ending appears here as posthumous justice. The child learns that the end of a story is not the end of justice: 'Time is the greatest court of all.'

From an Indian perspective, the tale unites vira and karuna, the heroic and the pathetic, in the manner suggested by Bhavabhuti's declaration 'Eko rasah karuna eva'—that compassion or pathos alone is the fundamental rasa. Dina's victory over the tiger is the height of vira, and the deception of the bagra immediately thereafter opens an abyss of karuna. This oscillation of rasa provides an emotional education for the child. The

image of milk forcing its way through seven layers of cloth brings vatsalya, maternal affection, to the point where physiology falls silent and poetry begins to speak: 'A mother's milk is the greatest proof in the world.' Socially, this epic is a manifesto for the Videha Parallel-History paradigm. The sharing of divine worship with two Musahar labouring brothers —'Deity and labourer, in the same courtyard, beneath the same incense and lamps'—is a statement of the democracy of Indian popular devotion that no sociology could express more beautifully. Intertextual connections are especially dense here. Salhes is a constrained deity in this tale but a struggling man in Raja Salhes (17); read together, the two books complete the folk deity's life-history, from humanity to divinity. Budhni's austerities are a dark counterpart to those of Moti Dai (27): the same method, stubborn ascetic devotion, serves opposite purposes, the taking of life and the desire for a child. Death through the deceit of the tigress in the guise of a bagra also connects with the pattern in Amar Baba (24) and Bahura Godhin (25): heroes die not through superior strength but through deception.

17. Raja Salhes: Freedom of Title and Justice Protected by Tantra

Salhes, a Dusadh soldier of Morang, has no throne, yet in the people's hearts he is 'king.' The landlord Naurangi Bahadur Thapa dislikes the title: 'Tell the people not to call him that!' The answer is, 'How can anyone control what people choose to call another?' Salhes leaves Morang because of this impossible command. Dabna, a woman of the gardener community who has tied a knot in her sari for twelve years and is learned in the tantra of Kamru-Kamakhya, makes him commander of seven hundred soldiers. The deposed Chuharmal conspires against him by concealing the queen's necklace, worth nine lakhs, in Salhes's bed. Through Dabna's ritual practice at the Kali temple, Chuharmal vomits blood and confesses everything. Salhes is freed, promoted, and finally married to Dabna.

The intellectual centre of this epic is the dispute over the title, a first lesson in political philosophy for the young reader. Who has a monopoly over the word 'king'—political authority or society? Salhes's argument ('The people gave me this title … even if I renounce it, they will continue to use it') is an argument for democracy in language. A name exists in the minds of those who give it, and no landlord can command their minds. In the vocabulary of Zipes's ideological analysis, this narrative stages a collision between two sources of legitimacy: authority derived from office and authority derived from service. The folk tradition votes unequivocally for the latter. The second subject for criticism is Dabna. She is a rejected lover who chooses evidence rather than revenge: her tantric knowledge serves as a 'forensic' instrument, compelling the guilty man literally to vomit the truth. Supernatural power is therefore placed in the service of due process, not

retaliation. The motif of waiting twelve years recurs throughout the collection (compare Jyoti Panjiyar, 31; Naika Banijara, 21; and Madhuvan in Raja Dholan, 15). Twelve years is the complete measure of ascetic endurance in the folk imagination, and Dabna's love is measured by that span.

From the standpoint of aucitya, or propriety, the author reduces the opening incident of a physician's suicide to a single informative paragraph—an appropriate compression for young readers—and places the narrative weight upon exposing the conspiracy. Chuharmal's ordeal ('vomiting blood') is situated within supernatural punishment, where a child may understand it as magical justice rather than physical violence. At the intertextual level, the book creates one of the collection's most intriguing puzzles of names. The villain 'Chuharmal' in this story and the hero Chuharmal of Chuharmal and Reshma (18) share a name but inhabit different character-worlds. This is a sign of the historical tension within folk tradition: the Salhes epic and the Chuharmal epic have been songs of pride for different communities. By granting each figure his own heroism within his own narrative, the author preserves that plurality of voices. The young reader learns indirectly that the story associated with one name can change with the storyteller's location and that history's multiplicity of voices is not a flaw but an inheritance. Reading the constrained deity of Dina-Bhadri (16) alongside the struggling human being of this tale is the proper way to read this pair.

18. Chuharmal and Reshma: Vermilion of Blood — A Memorial to Forbidden Love

Mokama Ghat. Chuharmal, a Dudh-bansi labourer and wrestler, and Reshma, daughter of a Bhumihar mansion: love at first sight comes from Reshma, while Chuharmal says 'no' for years. 'You are a daughter of the mansion; I am a labourer at the ghat.' When their secret becomes known, surveillance follows; the hired killers Ramjit and Manne Khan are themselves slain; the mansion's men attack the Dudh-bansi settlement; and Reshma herself stops them: 'If innocent blood is to be shed because of me, let mine be shed first!' With Ramsakhi's magic the lovers meet unseen. They marry in the Kali temple, where Chuharmal fills the parting of Reshma's hair with his own blood instead of sindur. Then come encirclement, the protection of Reshma in a mahua tree, and the final battle. At the very instant the hero is winning, a soldier named Kalua abducts Reshma, the horse is killed, and Chuharmal dies calling 'Reshma, Reshma.' At the end stand the Reshma-Chuharmal temple in the Mokama wetlands and a fair attended by all castes.

This is the collection's supreme tragedy of love, and the key to its criticism is an image worthy of being called Maithili's own contribution to the world's literature of love: vermilion made of blood. Sindur symbolises the

institution of marriage; blood symbolises life. Their exchange declares that where an institution refuses to provide love with the materials of recognition, love fashions those materials from its own body. A Western comparison naturally recalls Romeo and Juliet—love between hostile families, a secret marriage, a tragic ending—but the difference is decisive. Shakespeare's feud is between two families of equal status, whereas the antagonism here is vertical, arranged along a ladder of caste and class. The tragedy is structural, not fated; its villain is not a single person but 'all those walls that have been erected between one human being and another.' Reshma's characterisation deserves particular attention. She initiates the love, an uncommon role in folk epic; she mediates to protect the settlement and devises ways to evade surveillance. By Nikolajeva's measure she possesses full agency. Yet the epic ultimately leaves her fate in silence. The author's observation, 'This silence is more painful than any description,' is an excellent application of aucitya: where the folk variants are multiple and distressing, silence in an adaptation for children is both a form of respect and a deliberate restraint.

In terms of rasa, karuna triumphs over a conjunction of sringara—not consummation, but love at its first awakening—and vira. The final chapter, however, changes pathos into santa, or peace, through the temple and fair: 'The lovers die; love becomes a fair.' This posthumous communal recognition is a secular counterpart to Salhes's promise of worship in Dina-Bhadri (16): there a deity asks forgiveness; here society does. In both cases memory is the court of final justice. Comparison with Munga and Jalim Singh (19) is indispensable and will be pursued in the next study. For now, one may note that there too the marriage mark is made with blood, but the ending is happy. Together the two epics place before the young reader the two possible fates of inter-caste love—the triumph of society and the triumph of love—without offering false reassurance.

19. Munga and Jalim Singh: The Same Fire, a Different Ending

The kingdom of Bettiah. Rajput commander Jalim Singh and Munga, a young woman of the Dudh-bansi community, meet for the first time beside a well. The court flatterer Prithvipal poisons others' minds against them. Pattu, a Mallah, single-handedly destroys an attacking force and finally sacrifices his life for his master. Jalim disregards his guru Mauni Baba's command to 'give up Munga's company.' In the forest is Kanua, who consumes a maund and a quarter of milk and a goat for nourishment and rides a buffalo that hunts tigers; Munga has been bound beneath his sword. Jalim arrives at the critical moment, kills the buffalo and Kanua, and there in the forest applies the vermilion of blood. Then begins the war within his own household: his brother Kunwar's rebellion, their mother's acceptance, the brother's attack and the resulting wounds, Munga's

sleepless vigil at the physician's door. At last the weeping mother and brother repent and the lovers are taken 'home with love.'

This epic is the companion text to Chuharmal and Reshma (18), and placing the two face to face is one of the central exercises of this book of criticism. Count their shared elements: inter-caste love; a first meeting by water (a ghat or a well); a jealous conspirator; the sacrifice of a loyal supporter (the settlement in one story, Pattu in the other); vermilion of blood; and violence from the hero's own side. The outcomes, however, are reversed, and analysing why is the true critical work. In Reshma's story the source of violence, the mansion, remains implacable to the end. In Munga's story the source of violence, the brother, reaches repentance. Thus the folk memory as edited by the author preserves the possibility that the fortress of caste may be breached from within when some link in the family, such as the mother, first gives way: 'The mother's acceptance was the first foundation of this new household.' For young readers the pair provides the measured combination of hope and reality that theorists of children's literature recommend repeatedly. An exclusively happy ending would tell a lie; an exclusively tragic one would bring despair.

The epic also has independent distinguishing qualities. First, the episode of Mauni Baba—the realised guru's command and the hero's silent disobedience—is a rare moment of courage in folk narrative. The story does not treat a guru's words as final truth ('Destiny is greater even than a holy man's utterance'); this respectful defiance on behalf of love connects with that tradition of devotional poetry in which love itself is evidence. Second, Kanua's portrayal—his enormous appetite, his tiger-hunting buffalo—uses the idiom of folk hyperbole to measure terror by sheer size. For a child's imagination this larger-than-life adversary provides an exciting narrative grammar. Third, Pattu's sacrifice: the death of this Mallah companion announces the tale's scale of moral values. The epic never forgets the cost of loyalty ('Jalim never forgot the price of that friendship throughout his life'). This thread belongs to the collection's chain of friendship narratives (Lalmain Baba, 29; the stone friend in Brahman and Thakur, 12; and Jitan Yadav in Dina-Bhadri, 16). The movement through sringara, vira, and karuna completes its circle in santa; the last line, tracing the journey 'from an ordinary meeting by the well … to the family courtyard,' is its succinct formula.

20. Mahua Ghatwarin: A Daughter Sold and the Freedom of the Current

Mahua of Parman Ghat is a beautiful, virtuous girl, 'like a pinch of saffron in kneaded dough.' Her father is addicted to cannabis; her stepmother casts furtive, calculating glances. On a night in the months of Sawan and Bhadon she is forced to go and massage oil into a merchant's body. There

is Phulmati's consolation and the memory of the beloved waiting in Morang; then comes a messenger's secret news: her stepmother has sold her to the trader. Midstream, the oar is taken away from her: 'The entire payment has been made.' Mahua then does what makes this epic immortal: without warning she jumps into the current, swimming against it towards Morang. The trader's younger guard, who had begun to love her secretly, jumps in after her, and both drown. At the end, the ferryman catches sight of Mahua in the Sawan-Bhadon flood, and with each appearance the story begins again: 'Once there was Mahua Ghatwarin …'

This is the most deeply affecting work of pathos in the collection, and it demands courage from criticism, for its subject falls outside the supposedly 'safe' list of subjects for children's literature: the sale of a daughter. The author's skill in aucitya reaches its highest point here. Commercial details of the transaction are not the centre of the narrative; the girl's experience of it is: 'She had simply been turned into an article of trade, without her consent.' Mahua's question—'Why did you not kill me with a taste of salt instead of raising me for this day?'—enters the young reader's heart directly because it speaks not the language of economics but of betrayal. From a Western critical perspective the essay understands Mahua's leap not as self-destruction but as the final expression of agency. In the narrative's own words, 'This was not surrender; it was her last plan of self-defence.' She leapt not towards death but towards Morang—towards love and freedom—and the river current defeated her. This distinction needs to be underlined for adult mediators of the tale, teachers and parents: the epic teaches resistance, not flight from responsibility. 'I shall not be sold' is its fundamental declaration.

The stepmother is among the most widespread figures in world folklore, from Cinderella to Hansel and Gretel. Bettelheim interprets her as a split projection of a child's ambivalence, the good mother and the harsh mother. Here, however, that psychological figure is outweighed by social reality. Folk epic knows that the sale of daughters by the ghats of Mithila has not been merely imaginary. The younger guard's leap is the most delicate touch in the narrative: a heart rebels from within the machinery of oppression. A purchased guard reclaims his humanity, even at the price of his life; this detail saves the story from reducing its characters to simple villains. The cyclical ending, in which each sighting renews the telling, is a self-portrait of oral tradition. Mahua is immortal because she continues to be narrated; the tale announces its own secret of survival. There is also an intertextual connection with Moti Saeri (26): in that tale a daughter is floated away inside a chest; here a daughter is sold upon the current. Both are narratives of daughters carried away by water, and in both the daughter ultimately acquires an almost river-divine presence in communal memory. The frightening beauty of the Sawan-Bhadon current also connects with

the seasonal cycle of the Jat-Jatin rain ritual (36): in the same Bhadon waters, people in one place make a dance and elsewhere lose Mahua.

21. Naika Banijara: Testimony for the Absent Husband — Recognition through a Ring

Shobhanayak, a merchant's son, marries and leaves for Morang before enjoying domestic happiness. On the way he overhears a conversation between a dakhar couple beneath a tree: 'This is an exceedingly auspicious night; whoever stays with his wife tonight will have a gifted son.' Shobhanayak secretly returns home, leaves a ring as a token of recognition, fearing public scandal, and goes back to Morang. He trades there for twelve years. Meanwhile his pregnant wife Bari is suspected by her parents-in-law, expelled, and sheltered by her brother-in-law Chaturgan. There is the lament of a folk song: 'Then Bari weeps, tormented and distraught, oh no.' In the thirteenth year Shobhanayak returns. The ring establishes the truth, and the family is reunited.

The epic represents the recognition tale, that ancient narrative pattern in which the truth concerning a separated couple depends upon a token object. One naturally recalls the ring in the Sanskrit dramatic tradition of Abhijnanashakuntalam, and the recollection is appropriate: in both, society suspects a woman's character and an object resolves the doubt. The difference is that Shakuntala's ring is lost, and the play creates a tragedy of forgetting; here the ring is preserved, and the tragedy arises from absence rather than forgetfulness. The real critical question is ethical, and an honest reading must raise it. Shobhanayak gave the ring to Bari but did not tell his parents the truth. His device for avoiding 'public scandal' became the cause of twelve years of disgrace for Bari. The epic does not make an explicit accusation, but the pathos of Bari's song is a silent indictment. The proposition advanced in the discussion of Raja Dholan (15)—that family suffering is born more often of concealment than of conspiracy—receives further evidence here. For the young reader this paired reading is valuable: in both stories a man's supposedly 'protective' silence becomes a woman's prolonged suffering.

Chaturgan, who knows the truth and gives shelter to the woman cast out, is the voice of conscience within the epic, showing that supporters of truth may remain even inside a family. He is a counter-image to Kunwar (19): the brother in that story was violent, whereas this one protects. The episode of overhearing the dakhar couple belongs to a worldwide folktale device in which a conversation among birds or animals reveals human destiny (compare the dialogue of lamps in Bhat-Bhatin, 10, and the washerwoman episode in Bihula, 33). This accidental and unpossessed source of knowledge is characteristic of folk epistemology: truth needs ears able to hear it, not technical expertise. Dominated by karuna, the story

ultimately reaches a peaceful, happy conclusion. Its lasting achievement is the line of Bari's song. Direct quotation of a folksong is comparatively rare in the collection and brings the flavour of the epic-singing tradition to the young reader. The musical element will receive fuller development in Madhav Singh and Amta Village (37).

22. Chhechhan: The Drum, the Wrestling Match, and an Arena of Dom Heroism

A drum hangs in the wrestling arena of Manikchand, the Dom chief of Sahidapur. Whoever strikes it must first fight his pet boar Chatiya; whoever defeats Chatiya must wrestle Manikchand; and whoever defeats Manikchand will marry his sister Panma. Chhechhan Maharaj arrives carrying a katta weighing five paseris. He fills his chillum with medani flowers, smokes, and strikes the drum. At first Chatiya runs away; when he attacks, Chhechhan seizes both his legs and tears him apart. Chhechhan then defeats Manikchand in wrestling, and the delighted chief marries Panma to him. In the latter part, Chhechhan cuts bamboo from the homestead of the Yadav folk deity Krishnaram, the golden elephant Subaran arrives, and the elephant places its foot upon Chhechhan's katta. The epic pauses at the announcement of this new contest, adding that folk memory preserves Chhechhan's 'ultimately victorious struggle.'

This is the most unalloyed embodiment of vira rasa in the collection. There is neither a love story nor a miracle of devotion: only a test of strength, staged in a wrestling arena. From a Western perspective it is a pure challenge narrative: a public challenge signalled by the drum, a graduated sequence of tests (animal, then human), and a stated prize. Its structural resemblance to medieval European tournament romance is noteworthy, but its social meaning is precisely the opposite. The European arena was an aristocratic stage; here it becomes a platform of honour for a social stratum that the caste order labelled untouchable. Manikchand's pleasure after his defeat ('he was not saddened; rather, he was delighted') is the moral jewel of the epic. Competition here is not the production of enmity but a way of forming relationships: 'This contest did not turn into hostility; it became respect and a family bond.' It would be difficult to find a more vivid lesson in sportsmanship for children. The defeated side is not humiliated but included.

In terms of rasa, the contest with Chatiya mixes heroism with a touch of adbhuta, the marvellous: the boar's initial flight is an almost supernatural acknowledgement of the hero's prowess. Chhechhan's preparatory smoking of medani flowers is a local gesture of folk heroism, shaping the hero through his community's ways of life rather than a classical ideal. The author neither glorifies nor censors it; the authenticity of the folk text is carried into the children's version. The unfinished contest in the second

half, involving Krishnaram and Subaran, is an interesting critical decision. The epic stops at a climax and states that its subsequent development is preserved in folk memory. This is an honest acknowledgement of the reality of oral tradition: a folk epic has no single 'final version.' For young readers the open ending invites an exercise of imagination. Intertextually, Krishnaram is an elephant-riding folk deity here but a Yadav chieftain hired to abduct a girl in Moti Saeri (26). This double form of a single name (compare Chuharmal in Studies 17–18) provides another demonstration of the many voices of folk tradition. The public drum challenge connects directly with Baidla's arena in Amar Baba (24). In both cases a riverside arena becomes a popular court of justice; the difference is that one arena is a den of oppression and the other a measure of honour.

23. Miran Saheb: Orphaned Before Birth — Vengeance, Restraint, and the Vigil beyond Death

The Sayyid family of Dilarinagar—father and all his sons—is wiped out in a single battle at Nunjagarh. A pregnant widow remains in the mansion, and Miran is born into mourning. His mother vows to keep him away from war and marries him young to bind him to domestic life. Yet 'when a heart has already made its decision within, its silence is not consent but preparation.' One morning his room is empty. Miran travels alone to Nunjagarh, touches its soil to his forehead and says, 'Abba, brothers—Miran has come.' He completes his revenge and stops there: no kingdom, no plunder. 'For him vengeance was not a fire to go on spreading; it was a debt that had been discharged, and the ledger was closed.' He returns; the title 'Miran Saheb' arises spontaneously. Even after his death the town remains peaceful: 'Miran Saheb has not gone away; he is on guard.'

This epic brings a distinctive voice into the heroic section: the story of a Muslim folk hero. With it comes evidence that Mithila's popular sacred world is broader than religious boundaries. Just as Dina-Bhadri, Salhes, and Chhechhan acquired shrines, so Miran Saheb remained in the air as 'peace.' The central critical question is the morality of vengeance, and the author's treatment is unusually subtle. On one side he gives full dignity to the two voices counselling against revenge: the mother ('Vengeance does not bring the dead back to life') and the wife ('I too now have a claim upon your life'). On the other side Miran's departure is presented not as thrilling but as almost inevitable. The third and decisive touch is that the real test of courage comes not in battle but afterwards, in knowing when to stop. 'He closed the account and turned his horse around.' Such self-limited vengeance is rare in the world's repertoire of revenge narratives, and for young readers this is its protection under the principle of aucitya. The narrative presents violence not as a cycle without end but as a closed account. Compare Bal Guru (2): there the answer to humiliation was

recognition; here the answer to bloodshed is bloodshed. The collection allows both ethical positions to remain true within their respective narrative worlds and leaves the reader's judgement to find a path between them. Such refusal to decide is not an authorial weakness but a dialectical mode of teaching.

On the psychoanalytic level, being 'orphaned before birth' also places the narrative within grief literature. Miran's entire childhood passes beneath the shadow of an absent father: 'Blood speaks its own language.' His journey, in psychological terms, is an act of closure in mourning. Touching the soil to his forehead is a gesture of ancestral remembrance, not a gesture of war. In terms of rasa, the undercurrent of karuna within vira—the widow's threshold, the empty peg, the noiseless departure—brings the narrative towards a sentence from its subtitle that could serve as a formula for the entire collection's philosophy of heroism: 'Heroism does not roar here; it quietly performs its duty and departs.' The sociology of belief in the hero's posthumous guardianship may be compared with the bhagta traditions of Gariban Baba (28) and Lalmain Baba (29). The difference is that folk divinity there is bound to ritual; here it is a pure ethics of memory: 'Wrongdoers feared his name, and the distressed drew strength from it.'

24. Amar Baba: The Price of Protection — A Heroic Epic Examines Itself

The birth of the Kamala River, the life centred on farmers and boatmen, and the predatory designs of the chieftain Baidala upon the reputation of the young river: “I shall marry Kamala, by force!” The boatmen's penance brings a remedy from Bhola Baba: Amarsingh is born in the village of Shivra, his body is forged in the wrestling arena, he throws Baidala to the ground and kills him with a final throw. But the epic does not stop there. The crowd, fearing the survival of Baidala's family, demands that “the entire lineage be wiped out”, and Amarsingh kills Baidala's pregnant wife. “Here the epic lowers its eyes; let us do so too.” From the dead mother's womb a child is born twice as strong. Kamala herself reveals the secret of his death, and Amarsingh kills him—“He never told anyone that way.” In the evening Amarsingh sits alone on the riverbank, victorious yet burdened. After his death he becomes a gahmar, and the old boatman offers two prayers: “One for protection, and one for forgiveness.”

This is the boldest book in the collection because it criticises the heroic epic from within its own form. In the customary grammar of a folk-hero narrative, every killing by the hero is justified. Here the author breaks that grammar: “What happened was the darkest page of the epic … when the sword of courage passes into the hands of fear, whatever it cuts remains as a wound in the heart of the one who wielded it.” The killing of the

pregnant woman is neither justified nor erased as a stain merely imposed upon the protagonist. It is recorded as the consequence of collective fear —"Fear has its own logic, and a crowd its own momentum"—and its moral weight remains forever upon the hero's conscience. In Western critical terminology this is a narrative of moral injury, a wound inflicted not upon a warrior's body but upon his moral being. Its presence in literature for children is radical: the young reader is shown not an advertisement for heroism but an account of its moral costs. Fate's response —a son twice as strong, born from the dead mother's womb—is the seed-mathematics of recurring vengeance, expressed by the epic in a single sentence: "The reckoning is not so simple, Amarsingh."

From the standpoint of aucitya, or appropriateness, the statement that "the epic lowers its eyes" openly acknowledges the collection's technique of narrative restraint (compare Bagiyak Gachh, Study 5). The author does not give the child reader the violent scene, but gives the scene its full moral weight. This is the model of a children's adaptation in which simplification does not become suppression of truth. The concealment of Kamala's disclosure of a fatal secret—"He never told anyone that way"—beautifully imitates oral tradition's guardianship of mysteries: even an epic does not share every kind of knowledge. The movement of rasa proceeds from the heroic through compassion to tranquillity, but this is the tranquillity not of victory but of self-examination. The image of two final prayers offers a folk version of the Indian practice of expiation. Intertextually, Baidala's demand for marriage by force echoes, in worldly form, Mansa's command "Worship me" (Study 33): in both instances a relationship or reverence demanded by force is refused. The burden of protecting a river-goddess falling upon a boatman's son also links this work with Gango Devi's Bhagat (Study 30) and Bar Sukh Sar (Study 34), making it part of the collection's literature of water, to be considered together in the conclusion.

25. Bahura Godhin and Natua Dayal: Tantra, Dance, and the Beauty of Complexity

At the meeting of the Kamala and Balan rivers lives Bahura Godhin, a boatwoman's daughter: a stammerer, an adept of Kamru, one who can command trees to move and in anger turn a wedding party into bats. Dulara Dayal, a prince of Bharaur, learns to dance, becomes a natua, and falls in love with Bahura's daughter. Then come the machinations of the trader Jaisingh, the blinding of the minister Mall, and the journey to Kamakhya at the command of the guru Mangal. The prince learns the six dances from a yogini at the Chandika temple, their bodily movements from Bhuvanmohini of Sarraiya, and attains anahad and the ajna-chakra at the terrifying shrine of Vageshwari, together with a mantra against

black magic whispered into his ear. On his return he finds that Bahura has dried up the Kamala. Accusations fly; Natua's dance fills the river with water again; and his humble request for forgiveness transforms Bahura's heart: "Now you are worthy of my daughter." The wedding procession, three betel leaves, the mystery of a well-rope, and the restoration of Mall's sight follow. But at the wedding landing a disciple stabs his own teacher. Dying, Natua offers his cloth to Mother Kamala, and the river runs red with blood. The sorceress of Kamakhya revives him and offers the betrayer as a sacrifice to Kamala.

The author acknowledges in his introductory remarks that "this epic is complex, like the current of the Kamala-Balan itself"; the critic's first duty is to defend that complexity. A prevailing prejudice in thinking about children's literature holds that a narrative for children must move along a simple, linear path. Critics such as Peter Hunt repeatedly remind us, however, that children can cope with complex music, complex games, and complex relationships, provided that each turning point rests upon an emotional truth. The turns in Bahura's epic meet precisely this test: anger, discipline, forgiveness, betrayal, sacrifice, and revival all possess intelligible emotional logic even when their sequence of events is dreamlike. Bahura herself is one of the collection's most complex portraits of a woman: "She was loving, and she was terrifying." She kills her own husband to acquire magical knowledge, yet restores Mall's sight. The author's comment that "Bahura was kind at heart, terrible only in anger" teaches the child reader to interpret characters beyond the two rigid categories of villain and saint. This is an introduction to moral complexity and a first step towards the mature readership described by Nikolajeva.

The second dimension for criticism is the conjunction of dance and tantra. Natua's course of discipline—the six dances, anahad, and the ajna-chakra—makes artistic practice and yoga stages upon a single ascent. It embodies the proposition of Indian aesthetics that dance is not simply knowledge of the body but knowledge of consciousness. Making a river overflow through dance supplies the narrative proof. This is the tantric counterpart of Madhav Singh's rain-producing raga (Study 37): there, music bends the sky; here, dance opens the depths. Together the two works complete the collection's philosophy of art: perfected artistic practice acts in partnership with nature. The recurring cry "Ahi re ba" is a refrain of oral performance, preserved in the written text as a reminder that the epic can be sung. The final sacrifice raises a question of aucitya: this cycle of revenge is harsh for young readers. The author achieves balance by calling the sacrifice "a complicated form of justice", not an exemplary action to imitate, and by ending not with uncomplicated celebration but with the burden of reflection: "No simple happy ending." The Kamakhya thread links this epic to Dabna in the Salhes narrative (Study 17) and to Kamakhya's favour

in Raghuni Marar (Study 32). In the collection, Kamrup-Kamakhya is a school of folk tantra from which power is obtained; its ethical direction depends upon the purpose of the person wielding it.

26. Motisaeri: The Horoscope, Greed, and the Daughter Shut inside a Chest

Motisaeri is born through a sacrificial rite to the childless King Bhimsen of Morang. Reading her horoscope, the royal priest discovers that "whoever marries this girl will possess all the pleasures of the world", and greed leads him to fabricate a contrary prophecy: "If she stays, the kingdom will come to an end." The girl is sealed in a chest and set adrift. The current carries it beyond the priest waiting at the landing; Gaval, a chief of the forest, finds it and declares, "From today you are my daughter", raising her without inquiring about caste or lineage. The priest's second scheme is to advise the king, desperate for a son, to marry "the daughter of Chief Gaval". Gaval refuses. The king's army is defeated; half the kingdom is promised to Krishnaram; amid the deceit at Marchhaur, Motisaeri is abducted, and in the royal palace her unknowing father proposes marriage to his own daughter. Seeing the entire deception with divine vision, Motisaeri pronounces a curse: "A kingdom that does this to its own daughter shall cease to be a kingdom." She disappears into liberation. The kingdom is destroyed, the priest vanishes without leaving even a name, and a pale figure is seen at dawn in the forest stream.

This epic is the collection's fiercest social indictment, accusing the three kinds of greed named in the introduction itself: the priest's, the king's, and power's. The first critical point concerns the abuse of the authority of knowledge. Here the priest is the figure who holds a monopoly over interpretation—"Astrology in his hand, scripture on his tongue"—and the narrative demonstrates that expertise left unchecked can become more dangerous than royal power. It is the grave, political counterpart of Gonu Jha's exposure of imposture (Study 11). There, pretence is stripped away through humour; here it consumes a daughter's life and the existence of a kingdom. The second observation concerns Gaval: "What the river gives is a trust to be cherished." This forest ethic of adoption offers the verdict of popular wisdom upon the entire doctrine of purity of blood. The only happy chapter of the tale occurs where no one asks about caste or pedigree. From the Videha Parallel-History perspective, this is the moral centre of the epic.

The final marriage proposal, made by a father unknowingly to his own daughter, belongs to an ancient and worldwide class of forbidden incidents that tale-type indexes identify under unnatural marriage proposals. The author's handling of aucitya is especially circumspect. The incident stops at a single instant—"For a moment time stood still"—with

no descriptive elaboration. The narrative immediately reinterprets it as a trap "laid by the priest", shifting the moral burden onto the conspirator. Motisaeri responds not with tears but with fire, not with flight but with a curse, and thereafter with liberation. For the child reader she becomes a victim who is not defined by victimhood: "Not once did she lose in this entire story." A paired reading with Mahua (Study 20) is essential. Both are epics of daughters sold or cast into water, both find their final refuge in the river, and in both collective memory transforms the daughter into a presiding spirit of the current. The distinction is that Mahua jumped towards love, while Motisaeri rose beyond deceit. These divergent exits into karuna and shanta are two poles of the collection's examination of women's suffering. The final line—"The kingdom that sets its daughter adrift is itself swept away"—is a maxim of political ethics disguised as a children's story. In the terms of dhvani theory, the expressed meaning is the story's conclusion and the suggested meaning a warning to the present.

Part Four: Devotion, Folk Deities, Ritual, and Epics of Art

27. Moti Dai: Six Days of Motherhood — Devotion's Ledger and the Slate of Compassion

Moti Dai, a washerwoman devotee from Ujjaini, serves daily at the shrine of Mother Gahil, yet her own lap remains empty. While she makes cow-dung cakes one evening, women of the cattle-herders' settlement hurl words as sharp as barbs: "Barren … even the livestock will perish if they see her." Wounded, she turns to a devotion that rebels, digging up the shrine platform with her own hands and crying, "Appear, Mother!" Mother Gahil appears and goes to Indra's court to consult the ledger: "The fruit of a previous birth; no child is written." Moti Dai prepares to die; the goddess returns a second time to insist, and compassion adds a line to the decree: a child shall be born, but shall die on the sixth-day rite. Moti Dai answers, "For a lap that has been empty all its life, even six days are six ages." She experiences six complete days of motherhood; under the lamp of the chhathihari ceremony the child dies. Moti Dai then begins a second life as a bhagata, becoming an answer to the empty laps of others.

This is the collection's most refined composition in karuna rasa, for its compassion arises not simply from an event but from a choice. Moti Dai knowingly accepts six days of happiness and grief on the seventh, and that informed consent confers dignity upon the tragedy. Western criticism would recognise a folk discussion of theodicy, the justification of suffering under divine justice. The story constructs its answer at three levels: decree (the ledger), compassion (the goddess's insistence), and transformation of meaning (removal of stigma). The last is the subtlest: "Yet the sorrow of being barren ended for her." The child does not survive, but the mark of "barrenness" is washed away forever. The epic distinguishes sorrow from

humiliation and shows how humiliation inflicted by society may weigh more heavily than suffering attributed to fate. A young reader absorbs this distinction not as a doctrine but as narrative experience, together with a lesson in verbal violence through the women of the cattle-herders' settlement: "It is one thing to weep privately, and another to be called inauspicious on the village road."

From an Indian perspective, the digging-up of the shrine is a jewel of the philosophy of bhakti: "It was not rebellion; it was devotion's final language, as a child pulls at its mother's sari-end." A devotee's right to quarrel with the deity—from Sur and Mira to a folk woman devotee—is that democratic gesture of Indian devotion which raises prayer above supplication into a relationship. The goddess's two journeys to petition on Moti Dai's behalf bring the relationship to its height. Indra's ledger makes karma theory intelligible to a child, but the emphasis falls not upon the decree but upon the "slate" within it, "where compassion may add a few lines". The point of contact between fatalism and compassion is the epic's philosophical achievement. Intertextually, Budhni's penance (Study 16) and Moti Dai's are opposite poles of the same discipline: penance is a power whose direction depends upon the devotee. The bhagata institution arises here from compassion; its male counterparts, Gariban Baba (Study 28) and Lalmain Baba (Study 29), arise from the cycle of justice. Together the three make a complete triangle of Mithila's bhagata tradition.

28. Gariban Baba: An Unwitting Mistake, Divine Punishment, and Collective Atonement

Three friends from Udhra village—Barham Thakur, Ghasi Yadav, and Gariban the washerman—gather at the wrestling arena. Near it Gariban inadvertently touches with his foot the platform dedicated to Mother Kamala. Enraged, Mother Kamala brings a tigress from Indra's court as punishment. An unequal fight takes place in the arena; Gariban is killed, and his body is cast into the Kamala River. At the washermen's landing another washerman, inconvenienced in his work, pushes the corpse away into the current—a second unwitting wrong. In response to the anguish of Gariban's wife, his spirit speaks through the body of a bhagata: all the washermen must recover the body and perform the funeral rites, or clothes will burn in their washing furnaces. They search together, perform the proper rites, and remove the curse. From then on Gariban Baba becomes the guardian of the furnaces.

From the standpoint of the sociology of religion, this short epic is the clearest text in the collection. The entire making of a folk deity is displayed in four stages: an unjust death, dishonour after death, the spirit's demand, collective redress, and the institutionalisation of that redress in a new guardian of the furnaces. What an anthropologist of religion would

call a narrative of cult formation is available here in the simplicity of a children's tale. Its educational value lies in enabling children to understand the surrounding traditions of bhagatas and their sacred enclosures not as superstition or spectacle but as meaningful institutions of social memory. The central distinction in its moral grammar is between the unwitting and the deliberate. Both errors—the accidental touch and the pushing away of the corpse—occur without a stated wish to cause injury, yet consequences follow. The narrative teaches the difficult difference between intention and effect: even unintended harm requires social repair. An apology is not an admission that one meant harm, but an acceptance of responsibility for what one's action caused. In the language of contemporary ethics, this is a folk lesson in "accountability without shame".

A critic must naturally question the proportionality of the goddess's punishment: death for an accidental touch? The epic answers through its structure. It does not present the deity's punishment as an example to imitate, but uses it as the starting point and directs nearly all its energy towards restoration. The final chapter's assertion that "the victim may himself become a protector" changes a punishment narrative into one of transformation. Read beside the question of sacrifice in Battu (Study 6), the question of divine anger here produces a portrait of the relation between gods and humanity that is not free of fear but remains open to dialogue: a deity is not the last word, but another party to a conversation. The opening image of three companions—a Thakur, a Yadav, and a washerman sharing an arena—is the epic's social line of hope, which criticism should not overlook. Their caste names are given, yet in the arena they are companions; and folk divinity ultimately comes to the washerman whose labour with clothes and washing furnaces forms the axis of the tale. This consecration of work is a foundational proposition of the Videha Parallel-History perspective, further developed in Lalmain Baba (Study 29) and Raghuni Marar (Study 32).

29. Lalmain Baba: Hesitation Before a Tigress and the Weight of a Last Wish

Two Chamar friends from Nauhatta, Mansaram and Lalmain, graze buffaloes together. When a tigress attacks, Lalmain fights to protect the animals, but hesitates to exert his full strength against a female creature and is killed. His final request as he dies is simple: "Let my funeral rites be performed properly." Mansaram returns to the village without telling anyone. The angry spirit kills him by "making him bleat"; the village learns what occurred, collectively performs Lalmain's funeral rites, and brings peace to his spirit. Thereafter Lalmain Baba is venerated as a bhagata.

This is among the collection's briefest heroic-devotional narratives, yet its moral density is remarkable. The first critical issue is the hesitation that costs Lalmain his life: "He hesitated to strike a female tigress with his full force." This is a singular moment in folk ethics. The hero's code of valour —do not strike a female—extends even into the animal world. Although the story shows the fatal cost of such overextension, it does not ridicule the principle: "The cost of this sacrifice and morality was exceedingly great." In other words, the narrative acknowledges the tragic aspect of a moral rule without making the rule itself laughable. For the young reader this may be a first encounter with an expensive principle, and with a question that opens the door to mature ethical thought: ought one uphold a principle even when it costs one's life? The story offers respect rather than a categorical answer, and that respect teaches more than a ready-made answer might.

The second centre of the tale is the institution of the last wish. In customary ethics a dying person's request is almost a debt, and Mansaram's silence—whose cause the epic honestly leaves uncertain, "fear, self-interest, or neglect"—refuses that debt. The form of revenge taken by the spirit is severe for young readers; once again the author handles aucitya through restraint, disposing of the killing in a single phrase without description. The narrative's centre of gravity then immediately shifts to collective atonement. The pattern is precisely that of Gariban Baba (Study 28): an individual's failure followed by a community's repair. The parallel suggests a conscious pairing within the architecture of the collection. Washerman and Chamar alike become folk deities of labouring communities, and in each instance posthumous respect stands at the root of divinity. A sociological reading observes that folk religion creates an institution of honour after death for those who may have found honour scarce in life. Together these narratives plant in the child's imagination a first sense of justice in the distribution of respect. Along the axis of friendship and betrayal, this epic occupies a darker pole than the collection's tales of friendship (Pattu, Study 19; Jitan, Study 16; and the stone-friend, Study 12). Elsewhere a friend gives his life; here a friend cannot even give his word. Between these poles the child reader's own ethics of friendship can take shape.

30. Gango Devi's Bhagat: The Power of a Name — The Gentlest Devotional Epic

It is the fair in the month of Sawan. Gango Devi's husband goes fishing with his brother and father, hoping to sell the catch and buy bangles and lac bracelets for Gango. All day the net brings up only shells and other unwanted creatures. On the final attempt he casts it in his wife's name: "This is the last time, Gango … forgive me!" The net fills with so many fish

that it can hardly be pulled in. The same thing happens the following day. The brother and father still catch only shells and crabs, and the secret comes to light: Gango's name possesses power. The belief spreads among the boatmen, and even today Gango is remembered before the net is cast: this is the devotion of Gango Devi's bhagat.

This is the shortest and gentlest book in the collection, and criticism should begin by defending its smallness. The author himself underlines the point: "There is no monster, no battle, no complicated conspiracy here." That is precisely its generic courage. The elaborate apparatus of a miracle tale is reduced to a husband's address to his wife. What, then, is the source of the miracle? The story's own answer is psychologically exact: "This humility, this faith, is the true source of the miracle." The crucial words are the husband's admission of failure before his wife—"forgive me". Within the patriarchal grammar of folk tradition, that posture of address is itself a small revolution; the epic shows it as fruitful. The performative theory of language that appeared in Battu (Study 6) in the form of boastful speech appears here in its opposite form. There the utterance created fear; here the name gives rise to faith. Together they complete the collection's philosophy of speech: words derive their power from the feeling animating them.

From the sociology of religion, this epic offers a fourth and distinctive form of the bhagata tradition. Moti Dai (Study 27) attains divinity through compassion, and Gariban (Study 28) and Lalmain (Study 29) through cycles of justice. Gango does so without death or suffering, purely through a memory of love. "A private experience within one family became a collective belief": this is the gentlest possible birth narrative of folk religion. Notice also its labouring world. The devotional story is at the same time an account of livelihood, of nets, fishing grounds, markets, bangles, and lac bracelets. Devotion does not replace work but accompanies it; the remembrance before casting the net is followed, of course, by the casting. For a child reader the structure of its message is exemplary. There is wonder, which nourishes imagination, but it is no lottery: it rests upon a triangle of relationship, humility, and effort. Between the penance of boatmen in Amar Baba (Study 24) and the grace of the Ganga in Bar Sukh Sar (Study 34), this is the middle voice in the devotional literature of the river-dwelling communities. The three works together establish that, in Mithila's water culture, the river is at once a livelihood, a goddess, and a witness.

31. Jyoti Panjiyar: Twelve Years for a Refusal — From Curse to Blessing

Jyoti Panjiyar, a tantric adept of Pampipur, is absorbed in building a sacred enclosure, or gahbar. Dharmaraj, the family deity, approaches disguised as a beggar and asks for alms "from Jyoti's own hands". Jyoti refuses: "I shall

not leave the building of the gahbar to come." The result is a curse of poverty and leprosy. Rebuffed at his sister's door, he takes shelter with a friend in Oitdal. A tantric directs him to worship Dharmaraj for twelve years in the banana forest. The shadow of the curse falls upon his journey: a saini tree that gives him shade dries and falls, and Koili, who goes to fetch water for him, dies in a storm. Dharmaraj appears in the guise of a buffalo-keeper and gives a sign; on a leaf is written, "This is Achhamitpur." A childless king receives a boon involving a goat. After twelve years of penance follows a chain of restoration: Koili comes back to life, the river runs again, the saini tree becomes green, and the hidden bond between the goat and the king's son is explained. Jyoti returns to Pampipur carrying the gahbar wrapped in his gamchha.

The philosophical centre of this epic is a recurring question in devotional literature: when service and direct encounter clash, which has priority? Jyoti is building a house for the deity and turns away the deity himself when he arrives as a beggar. The narrative's diagnosis is explicit: "Between work and devotion Jyoti chose work." The means became more important than the end. The curse therefore punishes an inversion of priorities, not necessarily arrogance but inattentiveness to what matters most. This subtle distinction is valuable for children. The tale warns not the lazy person but the excessively busy one—a failing of modern life that a child of any period may recognise in a parent or guardian. What follows is one of the collection's most moving images of contagious misfortune: a tree dies merely from providing shade, and Koili perishes while offering service. Suffering does not remain alone but spreads to those we love. Jyoti's response—"From now on, care at every step, lest anyone else be hurt"—shows compassion being born within suffering.

The twelve-year penance is the collection's fullest use of a time-measure also found in Dabna (Study 17), Maruvan (Study 15), the twelve-year charitable kitchen (Study 12), and Naika (Study 21). Its results are calculated through a sequence of revival: those who died through the curse live again through penance. This balanced ledger of harm and repair presents a folk ideal of justice; its opposite, the irreparability of harm, has already been shown in Amar Baba (Study 24). Together these works teach the reader that some losses can be restored and others cannot. The linked life of the goat and the prince—the prince will return if the goat is found—is an affectionate version of the folktale motif of the external soul. Here a life is not hidden in a monster's parrot but in an animal tied to a blessing. The closing image, "the gahbar in a gamchha", is the epic's answer to its own opening. The sacred enclosure, whose construction had become so weighty that Jyoti turned away the deity, has become light enough to carry in a cloth. Devotion has travelled from burden to lightness. That trajectory

prepares for the question of disguise and devotion's burdens addressed directly in Ugna (Study 35).

32. Raghuni Marar: The Armour of Devotion and the Court of False Accusation

Driven from his village by famine, Raghuni Marar reached Bidia Barhampur. He won the wrestling contest held by Jugal Prasad, received a gift of a hundred bighas of land, and established a cattle enclosure at Sugama. The estate was subsequently sold to the Gagori Raj. During a dance performance in the courtyard of the Chaudhary of Simri, Raghuni's generosity—a gift of a pair of cows to the performer—aroused the Chaudhary's jealousy. Makdum Jogi launched three attacks: enchanted mustard seeds proved powerless; a hundred tigers, summoned through mastery of Chandika, killed Raghuni, but Kamakhya restored him to life; and a third assault, the yogi's closed-fist binding spell, failed as well. Then came legal deceit: "He has not paid the rent, and he is stopping the others from paying." The soldiers seized his brother Devdatta; although Raghuni appeared along the road, he remained invisible to the soldiers. In the prison cell, the blows of the whip rebounded upon the man wielding it. The king acknowledged his mistake, released the tenants imprisoned for non-payment of rent, and sought from Raghuni the honour called *ghaṭṭī*.

This ballad exemplifies the collection's figure of the "invincible devotee." The key to its criticism is the three-rung ladder of assaults: magic at the individual level; physical violence in the form of a hundred tigers; and, finally, the machinery of the state—false accusation, arrest, and whipping. The narrative shows that when envy fails through direct force, it assumes the guise of an institution. The third weapon is more dangerous than the first two: Kamakhya can save Raghuni from the tigers, but the innocent brother becomes the victim of a fabricated charge. For a child reader, this ascending sequence provides an education in recognising injustice: injustice does not always arrive as a monster; sometimes it comes as a piece of paper. The final form of divine intervention, in which the lashes turn back upon the person administering them, is a poetic formula of popular justice that redirects punishment towards the punisher (compare the counter-condition in *Bhat-Bhatin*, Study 10, and the witch's retribution in *Bagiyak Gachh*, Study 5). The hero does not himself inflict violence: the system collides with itself. This imagination of nonviolent justice is especially appropriate to writing for children.

The episode in which the Chaudhary's jealousy originates displays subtle social observation. He interprets Raghuni's generosity, the gift of cows, as an attempt to make him appear inferior. The story shows that envy can arise not from humiliation but from another person's virtues. In the collection's chain of envious figures—the jackal in Study 8, Prithvipal in

Study 19, and Thapa in Study 17—this is the most delicate link, for the "cause" of jealousy is not any harm done by the victim but the manner in which he does good. The story explicitly identifies the source of Raghuni's invulnerability: "Raghuni was a devotee of the goddess; therefore the magic did not work on him." A critical precaution is necessary here, however. The formula of a devotional shield should not become, in a child's mind, the simplistic equation "devotee = invulnerable." The collection supplies its own counterexample: Dina and Bhadri (Study 16), despite their profound devotion, were killed through deception. Reading the two narratives together teaches the complexity of devotion's consequences. Finally, the king's request for *ghaṭṭī*—the punishing authority becoming a supplicant for honour—is one of those folk moments in which power is reversed. In Nikolajeva's terms, it offers one of the deepest pleasures of children's literature: the child, and the labouring person, witness the moment when the balance is overturned.

33. Bihula: Defiance upon a Raft — A Children's Recasting of the Manasa Epic

Chand Saudagar of Champanagar possesses fourteen ships and is an unwavering devotee of Shiva: "This head bows in one place alone." Manasa, hungry for recognition, leaves Kailasa and demands worship specifically from him. When he refuses, she kills his seven sons and sinks his fourteen ships, yet the merchant will not yield: "What value has a head bowed out of fear?" A spark survives in the heap of ashes: Lakhindar is born. He marries Bihula, blessed with unbroken married felicity, but even the lattice-work bridal chamber cannot exclude Manasa, who enters in a form thinner than the thinnest opening and strikes with her venom. Bihula sets out with her husband's corpse upon a banana-stem raft: "Where my married happiness goes, I shall go there too." A washerwoman's play between death and life at Triveni shows her the way. After austerities at Manasa's door, she asks not merely for her own husband: "Life for Lakhindar and for all seven of his elder brothers." Eight lives return, eight lamps of worship burn in Champanagar, and the paired worship of Manasa and Bihula begins.

This ballad is a Maithili children's recasting of eastern India's extensive *Manasa-mangal* tradition, and its art of adaptation is the first subject of criticism. The immense original tradition, running to thousands of lines of *mangal-kavya*, is condensed into a carefully shaped arc of twelve chapters. The author's distribution of emphasis is significant: the contest of stubborn wills between goddess and merchant occupies the first half, and Bihula's journey occupies the second. The ballad's centre of gravity thus shifts from a struggle for power to the pilgrimage of a woman's determination. Chand Saudagar's character offers child readers an

unusually complex gift. Is he a hero, or merely obstinate? The narrative answers: both. "His grief was a mountain, but his steadfastness rose higher than the mountain." His refusal of worship founded on fear—"A goddess who can take seven innocent lives is not asking for worship; she is demanding fear"—raises precisely the question of religious ethics that returns to children's minds and is so often suppressed. The ballad does not suppress it. Even at the end, resolution comes by gratitude, not terror: "Worship born of gratitude is always greater than worship born of fear."

From the standpoint of Propp, Bihula's journey is a fully recognisable quest: departure; encounter with a helper (the washerwoman as donor figure); severe ordeal; acquisition of a boon; and return. Its revolution lies in the identity of the traveller—a newly married woman—and in her means of travel, a raft carrying her husband's corpse. A comparable image would be difficult to find in world children's literature. The ballad offers a folk-traditional revision of the linear, masculine structure of Joseph Campbell's "hero's journey." Bihula's weapons are determination, service, and a question: "The goddess was angry with a man—why should the bride bear the punishment?" The enlargement of her final request—"She came for herself, but asked for everyone: that is what makes Bihula Bihula"—marks the leap from individual deliverance to communal welfare that distinguishes the Indian devotional heroine from the Western quest hero. The personification of Manasa's "hunger for recognition," a hunger "like a human being's," is an example of the folk tradition's courage in portraying deities. The concluding joint worship of goddess and human heroine is the institutional consequence of that courage: "In what other ballad is there such a union of devotion and power?" The intertextual density is considerable. The proverbial ending "Become Bihula" turns the tale into a living idiom (compare "attaining the Ganga like Bodhi Kayastha" in Study 34). The protective lattice-work bridal chamber is the inverse image of the chest in *Motisaeri* (Study 26): there enclosure was an injustice, here it is protection, and both fail. Again and again, the folk epic declares that fate does not obey a lock, but it can yield to austerity.

34. Baṛ Sukh Sār Pāol Tua Tīre: An Unblemished Life and a Literary Pilgrimage

Bodhi Kayastha of the Mithila court lived on his salary and gave away what remained in charity and pious works. Throughout his life he kept clear of violence and covetous desire; he was a devotee of Bhola Baba. Sensing that death was near, he resolved to obtain the blessing of the Ganga. From a distance described in the source as *adhā kos*, he called to the river. Mother Ganga broke through her bank, came to him, and took him into herself: he went directly to heaven. The incident belonged to a time before Vidyapati, who set it down in *Purusha-pariksha* and composed the

immortal Maithili lyric upon it: "Baṛ sukh sār pāol tua tīre" ("I found the essence of great happiness upon your bank").

This is the collection's briefest plot—one miracle and one principal figure—yet its critical significance is exceptionally layered, for it is a book of literary history as much as a storybook. The first layer is an inverse method of characterisation. Folk heroes are ordinarily known by their actions; Bodhi Kayastha is defined by his non-actions—what he did not do: commit violence, covet another's spouse or wealth, or hoard possessions. In children's literature this art of characterisation through "negative space" is rare and valuable. The story establishes an ideal without a single spectacle of heroism, and tests that ideal at the end. Calling to the Ganga from *adhā kos* away is an audacity of faith: "This was neither arrogance nor reckless daring, but the innocent appeal of a wholly surrendered devotee." The river's breaking of its bank is the response. In the vocabulary of devotional thought, this is a tale of "grace that crosses its own bounds": the rule represented by the riverbank yields before love. In Bihula (Study 33), destiny yielded to austerity; here geography yields to devotion.

The second layer is literary self-consciousness, and here this book is unique within the collection. The narrative tells its own literary biography: an event, its Sanskrit inscription in *Purusha-pariksha*, its transformation into a Maithili lyric, and finally its passage into a proverb ("Ganga's blessing, like Bodhi Kayastha's"). For the first time, child readers are shown the process by which an event becomes a book and a book becomes culture. This self-account of textual transmission is a foundational lesson in literary education. Vidyapati's presence also reveals a trilogy in the collection's architecture: *Baṛ Sukh Sār* presents Vidyapati as narrator and singer; *Ugna* (Study 35) presents him as a character; and *Jat-Jatin* (Study 36) presents the folk theatre arising from the courtly age of Vidyapati. Together they reveal to the child three aspects of the great poet—creator, devotee, and historical age. This teaching of literary history through narrative is an original pedagogical experiment. In terms of *rasa*, the story is a rare, pure example of *śānta-rasa* in the collection. Its depiction of death—willingly anticipated and suffused with grace—introduces dignity where children might otherwise find only fear. What Bettelheim identifies as a fairy tale's profound service, reconciliation with an ending, is accomplished here without a monster, in the embrace of a river.

35. Ugna: Mahadeva as a Servant — Devotion's Sweetest Reversal

On Kailasa, Shiva sways as he listens to Vidyapati's *nachari* songs and forms a wish: "I want to hear these songs while staying close to him." Taking the name Ugna, he becomes Vidyapati's servant. On a road in the fierce heat of Jeth, the poet faints; Ugna releases a stream of Ganga water from his matted locks and gives him a drink. The taste of that water reveals his

identity. Shiva imposes a condition: "The day my true name escapes your lips, I shall disappear." On Kailasa, the lonely Parvati devises a scheme involving *tetari* fruit. The tree is bare and Ugna returns empty-handed; then comes Chandana's broom, and from Vidyapati's heart bursts the cry "Ha, Shiva!" Ugna vanishes. The distraught poet wanders crying "Ugna re, mor katay gelah?" ("O Ugna, where have you gone?"), and a shrine to Ugna Mahadeva is established at Bhit-Bhagwanpur.

This ballad is the crowning jewel of the collection's devotional group. Its central marvel is the reversal the story itself calls "the sweetest inversion in devotional literature": the one who should be served becomes a servant, out of hunger for song. In the vocabulary of *bhakti* philosophy, this is the supreme example of God's tenderness towards the devotee. Its value as children's literature, however, lies on another plane: it is a tale of domestic intimacy. Shiva washes vessels, goes in search of *tetari* fruit, and endures a broom. "Mithila turns even its gods into members of the household—this is its greatest achievement." What greater religious lesson could a child receive than the possibility that the divine is approachable even in the kitchen? The inverse of Nodelman's "hidden adult" is here a "hidden god"; sustaining the disguise is itself an austerity: "Had he performed a miracle, the disguise would have broken; maintaining the disguise was also a kind of penance."

The tragic mechanism of the ballad is precise, and criticism must distinguish its three components. First comes the nature of the condition: the secret depends upon a name being spoken—and the name escapes at precisely the instant when devotion is strongest. Seeing Shiva struck with a broom, the devotee cannot remain silent. "He broke the condition himself; but why did he break it? Because of devotion." This self-defeating logic of tragedy—one loses what one wishes to preserve—is among world literature's deepest patterns, here enacted with clarity accessible to children. Second is Parvati's position: the tale does not make her a villain; her manoeuvre arises "from love's sense of entitlement." Third is Chandana's innocence: "She was angry with a servant, not with a deity. If anyone must be blamed, blame the love that turned God into a servant." Together the three components make a tragedy without a villain. A young reader may weep, but need not hate anyone: an exemplary lesson in emotional understanding. Finally, the song deepened by separation —"Grief is the poet's dive, and from that dive comes the pearl"—offers an aesthetic principle that will resonate as far as Madhav Singh (Study 37): the connection of art and suffering. Jyoti Panjiyar's (Study 31) question of "service versus direct encounter" is reversed here. There the devotee sent the god away; here the god asked to serve the devotee. Read together, the stories reveal devotion as a two-way movement.

36. Jat-Jatin: Women's Own Theatre — Love, Domestic Life, and the Ritual of Rain

The setting is the age of Maharaja Shiv Singh (1412–1446). The musician Jayat is said to have set Vidyapati's songs to ragas and raginis; he composed the *Jat-Jatin* play and himself performed the role of Jat. This folk theatre, performed by women on the bright nights of Sawan and Bhadav, features Jat and Jatin and their groups of female companions. Its episodes include Jatin's insistence on visiting her natal home and the intervening flood; discussion of the rules for sending off a bride; an invitation to the *jhumar* dance ("On what leaf will you ride?"—"On the leaf of the water lily"); a symbolic wedding; the sale of even an elephant to satisfy demands for jewellery; departure for Morang; rejection of a goldsmith's temptation; anger at the touch of *chhauṅkī*; a home infested with insects and spiders; and reunion. At the end comes a frog-beating rain ritual and the throwing of the frog at the door of a quarrelsome woman: "The more abuse, the more rain."

Generically, this book is extraordinary within the collection. It does not retell a story; it narratively documents a living folk drama, and its critical vocabulary must therefore come from theatre studies. The first proposition is that this is women's own theatre. Its composition is attributed to a man, Jayat, but performers, characters, and audience are all women. Within a patriarchal society, this seasonal "space of their own"—a liminal space in Victor Turner's terminology—allows the subdued voices of domestic life to speak on stage: longing for one's natal home, desire for ornaments, humiliation at the touch of *chhauṅkī*, fear of a co-wife. The audience of women sees "a glimpse of its own life." This vernacular form of drama therapy deserves the critic's respect. Its value for children is twofold: girls encounter the cultural inheritance of their mothers and aunts, while boys encounter domestic feelings that are often excluded from their studies.

The second proposition concerns the ritual dimension, and criticism must be candid here. The rain rite involving the beating of a frog is a classic example of sympathetic magic; an analysis in the tradition of Frazer's *The Golden Bough* applies directly. Yet the episode sits uneasily with modern children's sensibilities and with compassion towards animals, which the collection itself nurtures in the episodes concerning the *sadhin* (Study 15) and the cuckoo (Study 31). The author's treatment is documentary, not prescriptive: the act is recorded as a "ritual linked to folk belief," not glorified. The critical recommendation is that an adult mediator should make this chapter an occasion for discussion. Folk tradition is not an object in a museum but a living river that continues to change course. Deciding what deserves preservation and what calls for reconsideration is part of cultural education. Structurally, the play's arc—union, quarrel,

separation, reunion—is a complete seasonal cycle of marriage. Its parallel with the rain cycle (estrangement as drought, reunion as rain) is the ballad's deep metaphor: domestic life and agriculture follow the same weather. This third panel of the Vidyapati trilogy (Studies 34–36) supplies the social and cultural setting of the age; its seasonal kinship with the Sawan–Bhadav of Mahua (Study 20) completes the collection's "Bhadav literature": one swollen current, carrying sorrow in one place and celebration in another.

37. Madhav Singh and Amta Village: Raga Megh-Malhar — The Final Note of an Epic of Art

Mithila is afflicted by famine. At a deliberation in the court, mention is made of four musician brothers at the Nepal court. Radhakrishna and Kartaram arrive, practitioners of *dhrupad*, accompanied by the *pakhawaj* player Bhim Mallik. Clouds gather during the *nom-tom* alap; the first drops fall with the measured strokes of the composition, followed by a downpour so heavy that water enters the court itself. Messengers go from village to village and report, "There is no dry place anywhere." Only then does the singing stop. In gratitude the king settles the two brothers in Amta, where the fruit of the *khiri* tree yields milk, and establishes a custom of listening to *dhrupad* there. As death approaches he makes a final request: "Take me to Amta; let me hear *dhrupad* once more." The palanquin is still on its way, before reaching Amta, when the king dies. That evening the fruit of the *khiri* tree sheds "tears instead of milk." After a long silence, a *tanpura* sounds again in Amta: the first raga is Megh-Malhar, and rain falls without clouds.

This final ballad, in the order adopted for this review, has been deliberately placed here because it is the concluding chapter of the entire collection's aesthetics of art. "This is an epic not of the sword but of the musical note." The opening declaration sets a theory of alternative power against the heroic group's whole vocabulary of weapons: accomplished art participates in nature itself. "If the raga is true and the discipline complete, even the sky becomes a listener." The story of music bringing rain belongs to the familiar family of Indian musical beliefs that attribute the power of rainfall to Megh-Malhar. Criticism should read it not as a scientific claim but as a metaphor of faith in art, and the metaphor has depth. Drought here is more than weather; it is the draining away of a society's life force, and music becomes its restoration. "To sing a raga here is not to provide music; it is to return life." The intended paired reading with Gonu Jha (Study 11)—the same drought, false austerity as against genuine discipline—has already been discussed there. What remains to add is that together the two tales provide children with a test of authenticity: not the grandeur of a claim, but the depth of practice.

The latter half of the ballad, centred on an unfulfilled last wish, is the collection's most restrained tragedy: "No curse, no battle—only an unfinished desire." Death is not punishment here, nor an obstruction deliberately imposed; it is simply the road falling short. In children's literature this third face of death, after the gracious death of *Baṛ Sukh Sār* and the battlefield deaths of the heroic narratives, completes a spectrum of learning about mortality. Children discover that some wishes remain unfulfilled, yet a life is not thereby worthless. "The king remained on the road—but in the story he reached Amta, for ever." This final sentence, immortality through storytelling, is the collection's self-description. All thirty-seven books do the same: those who were left on the road—the Musahar brothers, the Ghatwarin, the labourer, the woman devotee, the king—are carried to their destination by narrative. Kartaram's grieving silence and his return with Megh-Malhar ("an offering of melody is the true rite for the dead") enact the principle of Ugna's song of separation (Study 35). The milk-tears of the *khiri* tree are the collection's last unforgettable image of compassion: nature is not a spectator but a fellow mourner.

Epilogue: Thirty-Seven Books, One Literary World

At the end of these thirty-seven reviews, let us return to the question raised in the introduction: are these thirty-seven independent books, or do they constitute a single literary world? The evidence gathered along the course of the reviews supports the second answer. Its principal pillars can now be identified.

The first pillar is a recurring artistic signature. The narrative openings associated with Ba-Om (Studies 1 and 4) open the collection, and close it in humour, as a renewal of the *Panchatantra* tradition. The visual rhythm of the picture panels creates a double reading of word and image in the books. Most distinctive of all is the technique of narrative restraint: "the ballad lowers its eyes" (Study 24); "that is something the ballad will not describe in detail" (Studies 5 and 26); and the resolution of a death scene in a single sentence (Studies 4, 10, and 29). Such restraint is the golden mean of a children's edition: it preserves the darkness that Bettelheim considers necessary while maintaining a restraint consonant with *aucitya*—simplification without suppressing the truth. Alongside this, the narrator's aphoristic voice ("Revenge returns home, but justice returns"; "Time is the greatest court"; "Lovers die, but love becomes a fair") gives the collection a common treasury of wisdom. The ending "Even today …" in almost every ballad connects narrative to a living tradition and declares the continuity of collective memory.

The second pillar is an intertextual web whose knots have been revealed throughout the sequence of studies: the dual Salhes figure (Studies 16–17);

the doubling of the names Chuharmal and Krishnaram (Studies 17–18 and 22–26); the paired images of vermilion made from blood (Studies 18–19); the two "daughters carried away by the current" (Studies 20–26); the twelve-year measure of narrative time (Studies 12, 15, 17, 21, and 31); the Kamakhya thread (Studies 17, 25, and 32); the four devotees (Studies 27–30); the sequence of prohibitions (Studies 6, 13, 14, and 35); the Vidyapati trilogy (Studies 34–36); the drought pair (Studies 11 and 37); and the literature of water—the Kamala, Ganga, Paraman, Jabuna, and Triveni—in which a river appears in five forms: livelihood, goddess, refuge, witness, and cremation ground. This network asks readers to place works side by side and compare them. That has also been the method of the present critical volume.

The third pillar is an architecture of values, distinguished not by unanimity but by dialectical tension. Forgiveness (Study 2) faces vengeance (Studies 16 and 23); the teacher's word, disregarded in Study 19, and the father's word, proved false in Study 14, are both questioned; the shield of devotion (Study 32) and the killing of a devotee (Study 16) coexist as truths; and the two destinies of inter-caste love (Studies 18–19) are placed together without false reassurance. The collection does not deliver sermons: it offers pairs of paradigms and leaves the arena of judgement open to the reader's discernment. This trust in children's ability to hold contradictions—the respect for the child described by Peter Hunt—is its highest expression. Above all rises the social vision at the heart of the Videha Parallel-History model: Musahar, Dusadh, Dom, Dhobi, Chamar, Mallah, Kewat, Rajak, and Marar all have their epics in the same series of books of honour; deities and labourers stand "in the same courtyard, before the same lamp and incense." Alongside them runs an unbroken line of female agency—Aastha, Mansha, Dabna, Reshma, Munga, Mahua, Bihula, Motisaeri, Maruvan, Bari, Bhat's sister, and Moti Dai. Together they make the collection a literature of equality as well as a literature for children.

Finally there is the historical significance of this literary world. Maithili children's literature has received three things at once: modern original imaginative writing, extending as far as dystopia; a systematic doorway for children into an encyclopaedia of folk culture—epics, tales, theatre, and music; and its own capacity to withstand criticism. These are texts that can be analysed by every standard, from *rasa* and *aucitya* to Propp and Bettelheim, and yield new meanings under each. A child who reads these thirty-seven books will not merely read thirty-seven stories; that child will read the memory of a language, the conscience of a society, and the future of a tradition. The critic who reads them must acknowledge that the Maithili children's novel is no longer a "field of scarcity": it is a rich, self-aware literary world in dialogue with other traditions, all of whose landing places belong to the same pond. And that pond is called Mithila.

22. A Comparative Study of Thirteen Translated Books [Sanskrit-to-Maithili Translations by Gajendra Thakur] — In the Light of Indian and Western Theories

Abstract

An Overall Review—Caturbhāṇī, Dāmaka Prahasanam, Hāsyārṇava, Āgamḍambara, Kādambarī, the Satirical Triad of Bhallaṭa, Kṣemendra and Nīlakaṇṭha, Palāṇḍumaṇḍana, Uttararāmacaritam, Abhijñānaśākuntalam, Mudrārākṣasam, Mṛcchakaṭikam, Bhagavadajjukam and Mattavilāsa: A Comparative Study of Thirteen Translated Books [Sanskrit-to-Maithili Translations by Gajendra Thakur]. An Overall Review—Caturbhāṇī, Dāmaka Prahasanam, Hāsyārṇava, Āgamḍambara, Kādambarī, the Satirical Triad of Bhallaṭa, Kṣemendra and Nīlakaṇṭha, Palāṇḍumaṇḍana, Uttararāmacaritam, Abhijñānaśākuntalam, Mudrārākṣasam, Mṛcchakaṭikam, Bhagavadajjukam and Mattavilāsa.

Keywords: thirteen · translated · books · comparative · from Sanskrit · translation · Indian · Western

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Detailed Criticism — From the Standpoint of Indian and Western Literary Theories

The Nature of the Collection

Taken together, these thirteen books—Caturbhāṇī, Dāmaka Prahasanam, Hāsyārṇava, Āgamḍambara, Kādambarī, the satirical triad of Bhallaṭa, Kṣemendra and Nīlakaṇṭha, Palāṇḍumaṇḍana, Uttararāmacaritam, Abhijñānaśākuntalam, Mudrārākṣasam, Mṛcchakaṭikam, Bhagavadajjukam and Mattavilāsa—constitute a representative selection spanning almost a thousand years of Sanskrit literature, from before the Gupta age to the seventeenth century, and the

full range of its genres: bhāṇa, farce, drama, prakarana, ornate prose poetry, śataka verse and satirical verse. There is an internal logic to this selection. At one end stands the "great tradition" of Kālidāsa, Bhavabhūti and Bāṇa; at the other, the "parallel tradition" of monologues, farces and satire, which brings into literature's centre society's disavowed spaces—the courtesans' quarter, the gambling house, the tavern and the corrupt assembly. Placing these two traditions in a single row is itself a critical statement: the history of literature belongs not only to its summits but also to its valleys.

In the Light of Indian Theory: From Rasa to Aucitya

Measured by rasa theory, these thirteen books touch both poles of the emotional spectrum. Śākuntala and Kādambarī belong to śṛṅgāra, Uttararāmacaritam to karuṇa, Mudrārākṣasa to the heroism of intellect, and the remaining body of works largely to hāsya. Yet the essential lesson is that no work is confined to a single rasa: there is pathos in Śākuntala, wonder in Uttararāmacaritam, an assembly of all nine rasas in Mṛcchakaṭika, and often a current of disillusionment beneath farcical laughter. Dhvani theory reveals both its limits in this collection: Bhallaṭa's indirect expression reaches a summit of asamlakṣyakrama-dhvani, while the overt satire of Hāsyārṇava approaches what might be called citrakāvya. Between them stand Āgamḍambara and Bhagavadajjukam, demonstrating that philosophy itself may be suggested. From the perspective of vakrokti, the collection offers a series of examples across Kuntaka's categories, from verbal obliqueness (Bāṇa's play on words) to compositional obliqueness (stories within stories in Kādambarī, and a play within a play in Uttararāmacaritam). Aucitya appears here in its most provocative form. Kṣemendra is himself among the authors represented, while the farces show that deliberate "impropriety"—a reversal of expected dress, speech and behaviour—may become a poetic device: a poetry of impropriety arising from the grammar of propriety.

In the Light of Western Theory: From Aristotle to Bakhtin

Comparison with Western categories establishes the collection's place in world literature. Uttararāmacaritam parallels Shakespearean romance; Mudrārākṣasa anticipates Machiavellian political realism; Kādambarī invites modern narratology; Bhagavadajjukam raises questions of personal identity before Locke; Caturbhāṇī anticipates Browning's dramatic monologue; and Palāṇḍumaṇḍana offers a parallel or antecedent to the mock encomium before Erasmus. If one Western perspective proves especially productive for the collection as a whole, however, it is that of Bakhtin, theorist of carnival, polyphony and the "culture of laughter." The entire array of farces, monologues and satires offers an Indian illustration of his proposition that alongside every "serious" culture there

survives a "laughing" culture. A culture capable of making its own laughter into literature—even an emperor of Kāñcī wrote a farce—was inwardly self-confident. A subaltern and feminist perspective, meanwhile, reveals a third thread: Śambūka in Uttararāmacaritam; Āryaka and Sthāvaraka in Mṛcchakaṭika; Vasantasenā and Ajjukā, two courtesan protagonists; and the crises of testimony facing Śakuntalā and Sītā. Marginal voices are recorded within classical literature itself. The critic's task is to hear them.

The Significance of the Maithili Translation Project

These thirteen translations belong to a considered project: bringing the entire spectrum of Sanskrit classics—from high drama to farce, from ornate prose to the satirical śataka—into idiomatic Maithili. Their literary-historical significance operates at three levels. First, the linguistic: the group tests the capacity of Maithili prose to carry Bāṇa's compounds, Bhavabhūti's pathos, Śakāra's distorted speech and Jayanta's epistemological language. Maithili meets each test with the resources of its own vernacular tradition. Second, the cultural: for Mithila, the land of Gaṅgeśa and Ayācī's Nyāya and of Vidyāpati's poetry, these translations are not an "import" but a homecoming of an inherited possession. Third, the formation of tradition: this deliberate diversity of genres makes available to Maithili literature the range that any living literature needs—the grave and the playful, the classical and the everyday, centre and margin, all voices sharing a single shelf. In this sense the thirteen books are more than thirteen translations: they establish an entire "parallel constellation of classics" in Maithili.

Caturbhāṇī

Four Sanskrit bhāṇas—Padmaprābhṛtakam (Śūdraka), Dhūrtaviṭasaṃvāda (Īśvaradatta), Ubhayābhisārikā (Vararuci), and Pādatāḍitakam (Śyāmilaka)

Introduction to the Work

Among the ten types of Sanskrit dramatic composition, the bhāṇa is the most unusual: a one-person, one-act performance in which a witty urban gallant stands alone onstage and, through the technique of ākāśabhāṣita—speech addressed to unseen figures—brings an entire city's variety of characters vividly to life. He speaks to invisible persons, repeats their supposed replies himself, and in doing so spreads before the audience the whole urban world: courtesans' streets, gambling houses, circles of gallants and learned assemblies. The four pieces of Caturbhāṇī—Śūdraka's Padmaprābhṛtakam, Īśvaradatta's Dhūrtaviṭasaṃvāda, Vararuci's Ubhayābhisārikā and Śyāmilaka's Pādatāḍitakam—are exceptional documents of urban culture around the Gupta period. Here the viṭa,

familiar in poetics as an "attendant of erotic love," assumes a form that might be understood as a practical version of the urbane man of the Kāmasūtra.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra treats the bhāṇa as dominated by the bhāratī-vṛtti, the verbal mode: the performance of speech is paramount. From the standpoint of rasa, the bhāṇa combines erotic sentiment and humour in extraordinary fashion. The viṭa is himself the emissary of love, yet his accounts of acting as go-between possess such a cutting satirical edge that humour comes to assume the force of the dominant emotional disposition. By the criterion of dhvani theory, the bhāṇa's ākāśabhāṣita is itself a theatrical form of suggestion: the presence of the character who does not appear onstage is suggested rather than stated. Viewed through Kuntaka's vakrokti, the lifeblood of all four plays is vākyavakratā, obliqueness at the level of the sentence. In Pādatāḍitakam, even after a courtesan has struck a man on the head with her foot, calling the blow a "favour" is obliqueness at its extreme. Kṣemendra's theory of propriety raises a fascinating question: how do the nearly obscene subjects of the courtesan's world become fitting matter for poetry? The answer is that the gallant's polished, ornamented language elevates the coarseness of his subject. Propriety of expression renders the impropriety of the object aesthetically manageable.

A Perspective from Western Theory

From a Western standpoint, the bhāṇa deserves recognition as one of the earliest mature forms of the dramatic monologue, a millennium before Browning's art of the soliloquy. Bakhtin's concept of the "carnivalesque" fits Caturbhāṇī closely: the courtesans' street is a site of "festive reversal of class," where scholars, royal officials and ascetics remove their social masks and meet as equals. The bhāṇa is a record of that inverted world. Bergson's theory of laughter—the mechanical imposed on the living—is evident in its characterisation: each person becomes a mechanism of his or her single fixed habit, the miser of miserliness and the libertine of lust. From a reader-response perspective, the bhāṇa is a genre that places exceptional demands on the audience's imagination. Iser's "gaps" (Leerstellen) occupy the stage in an almost literal sense: the spectators must create the invisible characters themselves. In this respect, the bhāṇa is an ancestor of minimalist theatre and the one-person show.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

For the urban gallant's verbal play, the Maithili translation can readily draw on a tradition of joking that stretches from Vidyāpati's descriptions of amorous mannerisms to the dhāṅni songs. The rhythm of ākāśabhāṣita

—repeating a question and then supplying the answer—has been adapted to Maithili's natural conversational style. Selecting vernacular equivalents for the terminology of the courtesans' world prevents the translation from becoming pedantically learned. In sum, Caturbhāṇī is a gallery of satirical portraits of ancient Indian urban life, and its entry into Maithili fills a previously empty chamber in the language's dramatic literature.

Dāmaka Prahasanam

A Short Sanskrit Farce — A Comic Reworking of the Karṇa–Paraśurāma Narrative

Introduction to the Work

Dāmaka Prahasanam is a brief yet well-constructed farce that places one of the Mahābhārata's most heartrending episodes—Karṇa's learning archery from Paraśurāma in disguise and receiving a curse—within a comic frame. At its centre is not the heroic story but "dear Dāmaka," Karṇa's gluttonous attendant, who has left behind bathing in royal ponds, betel prepared with five fragrances and muslin garments, only to suffer the hardships of forest life. His senses have become reversed "like an image in a mirror": he smells with his ears and sees with his nostrils. A prologue, Dāmaka's long monologue, a very brief initiation scene between Paraśurāma and Karṇa, and two soldiers' narration of the curse suffice to complete the farce.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

From the standpoint of rasa, this work occupies an unusual meeting point of humour and pathos. Dāmaka's lament about hunger represents ātmastha humour (in Bharata's classification, where the character himself becomes an object of laughter), but Karṇa's destiny carries a subterranean current of karuṇa. His silent endurance of a beetle's sting is sustained by transitory emotions associated with the heroic and the pathetic. From the standpoint of dhvani, the subtlest moment comes when Karṇa says, "I am not a Kṣatriya." In this one line there is vastu-dhvani: at the instant of uttering the lie, the seed of the curse has been sown. This is suggested, not explicitly declared. Dāmaka's description of the hermitage—an ascetic's daughter watering plants from a pitcher "as though a mother were breastfeeding her child"—is an appropriate imitation of the Kālidāsian simile. This island of śānta rasa within a farce creates the beauty of contrast. Making the castor tree announce "the time has come" is an amusing animation of the inanimate.

A Perspective from Western Theory

In Western categories, Dāmaka plainly belongs to the tradition of the parasite character: the food-obsessed dependent of Greek and Roman

comedy who follows his master like a shadow in the plays of Plautus and Terence. Dāmaka's monologue is a textbook instance of Bergson's theory of laughter. The body's mechanical rebellion, expressed in the reversal of the senses, and the inertia of habit, expressed in his dependence on royal luxuries, both constitute what Bergson called the mechanical imposed upon life, a primary source of the comic. Structurally, the farce is a miniature experiment in the mock-heroic mode: the disparity between an epic subject—teacher and pupil, curse and destiny—and a petty protagonist, the gluttonous servant, itself produces the satire. Incongruity theory, associated with Kant and Schopenhauer, explains the effect directly. From a modern perspective, Dāmaka's bodily lament—hunger, sleep, headache—is the body's resistance to the "great" plane of the narrative. In Bakhtin's language, the grotesque body brings an elevated story back down to earth.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

In the Maithili translation, Dāmaka's memories of food—"a sweet evening drink, betel enriched with five fragrances"—pass so naturally into the vocabulary of Mithila's dining culture that he comes to seem a local character. The irony of "I am not hungry" becomes sharper in Maithili. The straightforward exchange in the brief initiation scene ("I am not a Kṣatriya." "Then I shall teach you; come.") retains its dramatic dryness in translation. Resisting the temptation to embellish it is itself an observance of aucitya. In sum, Dāmaka Prahasanam shows that Indian tradition could laugh affectionately even at its most tragic hero, Karṇa—and that such laughter was not the opposite of reverence but its complement.

Hāsyārṇava-Prahasanam (An Ocean of Laughter)

A Two-Act Farce by Jagadīśvara Bhaṭṭācārya

Introduction to the Work

Jagadīśvara Bhaṭṭācārya's Hāsyārṇava ranks among the most merciless works of satire in the medieval Sanskrit farcical tradition. Its title, "An Ocean of Laughter," is itself a declaration: laughter is no subsidiary sentiment here, but an all-engulfing sea. In the kingdom of King Anayasindhu ("Ocean of Injustice"), the procession of corruption brings together the royal physician, astrologer, priest, police chief and guru—representatives of every "venerable" social institution—at a courtesan's house. Each invokes the authority of his own discipline while violating its very standards. The naming of the characters is satirical in itself: names such as Viśvabhaṇḍa and Kalahāṅkura carry reversed or mocking meanings. A character's name becomes a manifesto of his character.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

In terms of dramaturgy, Hāsyārṇava almost resembles a handbook of the pure prahasana: imitation of disreputable persons, the incongruity of costume and speech, and an experimental display of all six forms of laughter, from smita (the smile) to atihasita (uproarious laughter). Its comedy, however, belongs to Bharata's category of parastha: the poet invites us to laugh at the characters, not alongside them. By the criterion of dhvani theory, the striking feature is that satire frequently becomes directly expressed, in what Ānandavardhana might call citrakāvya. Yet a closer reading discovers in the entire farce a vast prabandha-dhvani, a suggestion carried by the composition as a whole: no individual character declares that the machinery of the state has rotted, but the whole work suggests precisely that. Kṣemendra's principle of aucitya becomes an inverted test. Every character acts in direct opposition to the duty attached to his social station, and this carefully arranged "impropriety" is the farce's ornament. Impropriety itself becomes appropriate. In terms of vakrokti, its abundance of puns and ironic reversals—abuse delivered in the language of blessing, denunciation in the metre of praise—forms a series of examples of Kuntaka's obliqueness through reversal.

A Perspective from Western Theory

Among Western categories, Hāsyārṇava's closest relative is Juvenalian satire. As in Juvenal's Rome, anger—saeva indignatio—is the fuel of laughter. Bakhtin's theory of carnival is especially productive here: the courtesan's house is the carnivalesque space where crowns fall away, the boundary between sacred and profane dissolves, and the "high" is brought down to the lower bodily plane. But where Bakhtin's carnival holds out a revivifying joy, Hāsyārṇava replaces it with dark despair. It therefore approaches dark comedy, or the misanthropic satire associated with Swift. Within Northrop Frye's theory of genres, it is a pure example of the "mythos of irony and satire," the narrative mode of winter: no green world emerges, no order is restored, and even the ending remains satirical. From a New Historicist standpoint, the farce is a document of the decay of institutions in its age; the very excess of satire becomes a kind of historical testimony.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The Maithili translation meets the work's hardest challenge—punning and satire embedded in names—through vernacular parallels. Maithili's own folk tradition of abusive joking, extending to the ḍahakana songs of marriage celebrations, gives the translation a cultural home. It should be observed that the coarse level of obscenity has been kept under control: the edge of satire remains, while mere vulgarity has been filtered out. Overall,

Hāsyārṇava is a mirror of satire in which any age can see its corrupt face. Its arrival in Maithili hangs that mirror on Mithila's veranda.

Āgamḍambara

A Philosophical Drama by Jayanta Bhaṭṭa, the Naiyāyika

Introduction to the Work

When Jayanta Bhaṭṭa, author of the Nyāyamañjarī, wrote a play in ninth-century Kashmir, an unprecedented genre emerged: the theatrical transformation of philosophical disputation. The protagonist of Āgamḍambara is neither a king nor a lover but Saṅkarṣaṇa, a brilliant young Mīmāṃsā scholar who sets out on a campaign against "āgama-āḍambara," the pretence practised in the name of religion. Over four acts, he successively encounters Buddhists, Jains, the Nīlāmbara sect, Śaiva practitioners and Cārvākas. Finally, through Dhairyārāśi, an experienced exponent of Nyāya, the drama arrives at the conciliatory doctrine of sarvāgamaprāmāṇya: all scriptural traditions have validity, provided they do not violate social welfare or promote violence. Contemporary politics under King Śaṅkaravarman—notably the prohibition of the Nīlāmbara sect—is directly present in the play.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

As an experiment in the production of rasa, Āgamḍambara is exceptional. Its dominant rasa is difficult to determine: there is humour in the exposure of impostors, śānta in the final reconciliation, and a form of intellectual delight that might be described in Abhinavagupta's language as pure carvaṇā—the savouring of argument. A question arises: can philosophical debate become a subject of rasa? Jayanta gives a practical answer. His scenes of disputation possess the same dramatic tension of victory and defeat as scenes of warfare. From the perspective of dhvani, the very title is charged with a double meaning: ḍambara signifies both ostentation and clamour. It suggests at once the noise made in religion's name and the pretence masquerading as religion. Judged by aucitya, Jayanta's balance is commendable. His satire targets imposture, not philosophical systems themselves. The Buddhist Dharmottara is presented as a scholar worthy of respect, while a degraded follower becomes an object of ridicule. This discrimination saves the play from crude sectarianism.

A Perspective from Western Theory

Its nearest Western analogue is Aristophanes' Clouds, a theatrical satire of philosophers. Yet Jayanta goes beyond Aristophanes: after mockery he offers a constructive philosophical conclusion. In this sense, Āgamḍambara is a "drama of ideas," an early forerunner of the novel of ideas—a conflict

of intellectual positions on stage a millennium before Shaw and Brecht. Bakhtin's "polyphony" finds surprising expression here. Each philosophical system speaks in its own recognisable voice; even the Cārvāka is allowed to state his case with full force, while the author's own voice waits until the end. In terms of contemporary comparative philosophy of religion, the ending can be read as a medieval declaration of religious pluralism. A New Historicist caution is nevertheless necessary: this pluralism operates under the patronage of state power, and the prohibition imposed upon the Nīlāmbara sect displays its limits. The co-presence of conciliation and exclusion is precisely where the play acquires its modern relevance.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The Maithili translator faced a twofold challenge: philosophical terminology and dramatic movement. By retaining technical terms such as pramāṇa, prāmāṇya and anumāna while presenting them in accessible explanatory Maithili syntax, the translation keeps both dimensions in motion. Because Mithila possesses its own Navya-Nyāya tradition—the land of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya!—this vocabulary does not strike Maithili readers as that of a stranger, but rather as a guest returning home. Overall, Āgamḍambara demonstrates that the Indian stage could turn intellectual debate into entertainment, an achievement that gives it a distinctive place in world drama.

Kādambarī

Bāṇabhaṭṭa's Prose Epic

Introduction to the Work

"Bāṇocchiṣṭaṃ jagat sarvam"—"The whole world is what Bāṇa has left over." This famous saying attests to the renown of Kādambarī. In the seventh century, Bāṇabhaṭṭa, court poet of Harṣavardhana, raised prose to a height that might make verse envious. The narrative mechanism of Kādambarī is itself a marvel: a story told through a parrot's mouth encloses other stories; three levels of successive births—Śūdraka, Candrāpīḍa, Puṇḍarīka, and others—intersect; and memory and forgetting play a game in which readers, along with the characters, seem to have forgotten their previous lives, until all the knots are untied at once at the end. Mahāśvetā and Kādambarī, two embodiments of waiting, are immortal heroines of Indian literature. After Bāṇa's death, his son Bhūṣaṇabhaṭṭa completed the latter portion, writing in the shade of his father's great tree of sentences.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

In terms of rasa, Kādambarī is a vast ocean of love-in-separation, or vipralambha-śṛṅgāra. Moments of union are rare and the waiting seems endless. Mahāśvetā's ascetic state carries separation to the very threshold of śānta-rasa; this meeting of erotic sentiment and tranquillity is Kādambarī's distinctive chemistry of rasa. Bāṇa challenges the school of dhvani: what Ānandavardhana would have called guṇībhūta-vyaṅgya, suggestion subordinated to the expressed meaning, is everywhere present in his ornamented style. Yet at the level of the entire work, the philosophical suggestion concerning karma and rebirth is an instance of prabandha-dhvani, suggestion operating across the whole composition. Judged by the school of rīti, Kādambarī unites the force of compound-rich Pāñcālī and Gauḍī styles with the sweetness of the Vaidarbhī manner. What Daṇḍin called padalālitya, elegance in the arrangement of words, reaches an extreme here. Śleṣa, or double meaning, comes naturally to Bāṇa; the denunciation of Lakṣmī in the Śukanāsopadeśa is such an intricate web of punning that it tests translation itself. From the standpoint of vakrokti, Bāṇa is a master of prabandha-vakratā: the oblique manner of telling the story is itself part of its meaning.

A Perspective from Western Theory

Within Western genre theory, Kādambarī is often advanced as a contender for the title of "the world's first novel." However disputed that claim may be, the structure of its narration is unquestionably modern: frame narrative, in a manner reminiscent of Shahrazad; embedded narrators; and analepsis, employed in ways that could supply a textbook for Gérard Genette's narratology. The parrot who narrates is itself a character in the narrative, while the question "Who is telling whose story?" continues to turn until the end. The centrality of remembrance and oblivion brings the work close to Proust. The inexplicable ache of a former existence arising in Candrāpīḍa's heart seems like a Sanskrit anticipation of Proust's mémoire involontaire, or involuntary memory. In a psychoanalytic reading, the apparatus of rebirth figures the return, across successive lives, of repressed desire—as in the disruption of Puṇḍarīka's asceticism—and thus Freud's "return of the repressed." A feminist reading could understand the waiting of Mahāśvetā and Kādambarī in two ways: as the idealisation of feminine passivity, or, in a deeper reading, as the tenacity of women's memory, which preserves the continuity of the story amid the male characters' forgetting and death. Here the women are the axis of the narrative.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

Translating Bāṇa's prose, dense with long compounds, into Maithili is an audacious undertaking. The translation divides extended compounds into

rhythmical sequences of Maithili sentences: semantic density is retained, while the reader gains space to breathe. Where a pun could not carry both meanings, one meaning is chosen and the other preserved in the manner of an explanatory gloss. In the pathos-filled prose of Mahāśvetā's story, Maithili expressions such as nor (tears), hiya (heart) and bāṭ johab (waiting and watching for someone) give Bāṇa's feeling the fragrance of the soil. Taken as a whole, this Maithili Kādambarī re-establishes in Mithila the tradition of poetic prose whose seeds were already present in works such as Vidyāpati's Bhūparikrama.

Bhallata-Śataka, Kalāvilāsa and Kaliyuga-Viḍambanā

Three Works of Satire — Bhallaṭa, Kṣemendra and Nīlakaṇṭha

Introduction to the Works

This collection brings together three ages and three styles of Sanskrit satire. The Śataka of the ninth-century Kashmiri poet Bhallaṭa represents a summit of anyokti, indirect utterance: wounded by King Śaṅkaravarman's neglect, the poet writes verses in which the sea, the wish-fulfilling tree, the parrot and poison all speak of human beings without naming any human being. In the eleventh century, Kṣemendra, in Kalāvilāsa ("The Pleasures of the Arts of Deception"), enumerates across ten cantos the arts of hypocrisy, greed, lust, the courtesan's profession, the Kāyastha scribe, intoxication, the singer, the goldsmith, diverse swindlers and, at last, the "art" of virtue. Under cover of Mūladeva's adventures, he produces an encyclopaedia of society's techniques of fraud. In seventeenth-century southern India, Nīlakaṇṭha Dīkṣita, in Kaliyuga-Viḍambanā, uses a hundred verses to expose thirteen categories of folly—among scholars, astrologers, physicians, poets, moneylenders, misers and those who ostentatiously advertise their piety, among others. At the end he bows to the Kali age itself, "where one's own imagination is law."

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

All three works demonstrate the power of three different instruments of alaṅkāra theory. The animating principle of Bhallaṭa's poetry is anyokti, or aprastuta-praśaṃsā: by describing what is not directly in question, the poet conveys what is. This is an exemplary figure for the theory of dhvani, because the implied meaning remains wholly unspoken. The phenomenon that Ānandavardhana—Bhallaṭa's Kashmiri contemporary—calls arthāntarasaṅkramita-vācya, the expressed meaning passing over into another, is brought to life by Bhallaṭa. In "Alas, Kālakūṭa! How did you arise from that ocean?" the sea is no longer simply the sea. Kṣemendra was himself an authority on aucitya-vicāra, the examination of propriety, and his satirical method puts his own principles into practice. By cataloguing

the "improprieties" of each social group—the goldsmith's sixty-four arts, the sixteen defects of the balance—he turns the scholastic style of enumeration, the method of the encyclopaedic lexicon, into an instrument of laughter: a science of cheating dressed up as a learned science. In Nīlakaṇṭha's writing, vakrokti is compressed to its utmost. Each verse has the sharpness of an aphorism; contrary indication, or viparīta-lakṣaṇā—as in "Blessed indeed are the practitioners of charms and spells"—becomes the sting. From the standpoint of rasa, the durable sentiment beneath the humour of all three is, in fact, disenchantment mingled with tranquillity: satire prepares the ground for detachment, particularly in Nīlakaṇṭha, who finally rests in refuge with Śiva.

A Perspective from Western Theory

Bhallaṭa's anyokti differs from Aesop's fables and from allegorical poetry: a fable makes its moral explicit, whereas anyokti leaves it to implication. It approaches emblematic poetry, but is subtler still. Because of his voice of resistance to a king, Bhallaṭa also has a distant kinship with Ovid's Tristia, within a literature of exile and disgrace. Kṣemendra's Kalāvilāsa displays the characteristics of Menippean satire: the blending of genres, an encyclopaedic delight in inventories and a trickster-protagonist. Mūladeva is a predecessor of the picaresque tradition, some five centuries before the Spanish pícaro. Nīlakaṇṭha's style is comparable to the Roman epigram of Martial and to La Rochefoucauld's art of the maxim: brevity becomes a weapon. Bakhtin's proposition that satire belongs to the "unfinished present," in opposition to the enclosed past of epic, applies to all three. That is why they still feel contemporary: their portraits of goldsmiths, astrologers and "honourable gentlemen" can read like the newspaper of the twenty-first century.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The translation adopts three distinct registers for three distinct styles: a free, verse-like, suggestive rhythm for Bhallaṭa; accessible, enumerative narrative prose for Kṣemendra; and sharply honed aphoristic sentences for Nīlakaṇṭha. A translated title such as "The Pleasures of the Arts of Deception" is already an interpretation. Maithili readers gain something particular from this collection: the region's own satirical tradition, reaching to Harimohan Jha, can recognise its forebears in this confluence. Taken together, the texts demonstrate that Sanskrit was not solely the language of the gods, but also a language of incisive criticism of everyday life.

Palāṇḍumaṇḍana-Prahasanam

A Learned Assembly in Praise of the Forbidden Onion — A Satire of Scholarly Society

Introduction to the Work

Palāṇḍumaṇḍana ("The Ornamenting or Praise of the Onion") is a delightfully sharp work in the late-medieval Sanskrit farce tradition. Its object of ridicule is neither a king nor a courtesan, but the scholarly community itself. The plot is simple and explosive: a gathering of scholars assembles to defend the eating of palāṇḍu, the onion, which the smṛti texts prohibit to Brahmins. Deploying the very skills of scholastic debate, the same tradition of proofs, and the interpretative ingenuity once employed to unravel the problems of Vedānta, they establish the scriptural legitimacy of eating onions. Names such as Liṅgojī Bhaṭṭa point towards a South Indian scholarly milieu. The humour rests on the contradiction that the entire machinery of learning has been put at the service of the tongue.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

In the classification of drama, this is a pure prahasana, an imitation of what is reprehensible. Yet what is reprehensible here is not a low-status character: it is the misuse of the method of śāstrārtha, or learned disputation. That subtle distinction lifts the work above an ordinary farce. From the standpoint of vakrokti, the entire composition is an immense exercise in vyāja-stuti, praise that is really condemnation: the more lavish the praise of onions, the more naked the scholars appear. According to dhvani theory, the implication behind the laughter depends on the audience's familiarity with śāstra. Only a reader conversant with Mīmāṃsā's procedures of proof will recognise the ironic employment of terms such as arthavāda and gauṇa-mukhya. It is an intriguing situation of suggestion conditioned by the sahṛdaya, the responsive and informed reader. In terms of aucitya, consider the poet's boldness: the idiom of scholarship is used to mock scholarship, without disrespecting the śāstras themselves. The satire attacks the misuse of the method, not the method. Among the varieties of laughter, the play moves from upahasita to apahasita; ultimately the reader laughs at the self, for the ability to turn private taste into learned doctrine through argument is not restricted to scholars, but is a universal human weakness.

A Perspective from Western Theory

Its closest Western equivalent is the mock-encomium, or praise offered in pretence: Erasmus's *Praise of Folly* (*Moriae Encomium*) and the older Greek tradition of adoxography, in which insignificant things—flies, baldness or fever—receive solemn praise. Palāṇḍumaṇḍana belongs precisely here: the

weightiest scholastic seriousness is applied to an insignificant subject, the onion, and laughter springs from that incongruity. In Bakhtin's terms, the work is a "carnival of eating," a rebellion of forbidden taste in which bodily appetite defeats the discipline of learning. The victory celebrates the "material bodily principle" that animates carnival literature. Read against ancient Greek discussions of the sophists, including Plato's accusation that they could make the weaker argument appear stronger, Palāṇḍumaṇḍana becomes a Sanskrit reflection on sophistry. It laughs at the gulf between the power of reasoning and the ethics of reasoning. In modern terms, it is among the early satires of motivated reasoning.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The Maithili translation gives this farce a particularly homely flavour. Mithila's gatherings of pandits, traditions of scholastic debate and affection for food are all familiar contexts; a discussion of the palāṇḍu can readily join the debates of a Maithil kitchen. The parody of technical argument survives in translation because Maithili has itself been a language of śāstrārtha. Ultimately Palāṇḍumaṇḍana is a major work in miniature: it shows that a tradition remains alive only so long as it has the courage to laugh at itself.

Uttararāmacaritam

Bhavabhūti's Drama of Compassion

Introduction to the Work

In Uttararāmacaritam, the eighth-century poet Bhavabhūti took up the chapter of the Rāma story from which poets had often turned away: the abandonment of Sītā. This seven-act play narrates twelve years of separation after her exile. It begins with the viewing of pictures—Rāma and Sītā looking upon images of their past in the first act, making memory itself a stage. It moves through the unseen touch of the shadow-Sītā in Pañcavaṭī and the encounter of a father with Lava and Kuśa, whom he does not know to be his sons. Finally, reunion comes through a garbha-nāṭaka, a play within the play. Vālmīki himself arranges a "happy-ending version" of the Rāmāyaṇa on stage, as though the accusation of public opinion can be answered by the voice of the people. "Eko rasaḥ karuṇa eva"—compassion is the one rasa—is Bhavabhūti's own declaration and the generative statement of the drama.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

Within the history of rasa theory, Uttararāmacaritam is a theoretical intervention. By making karuṇa its governing rasa, Bhavabhūti challenges the assumption associated with Bharata that love or heroism should

predominate in a visible art such as drama. He goes further, declaring compassion the sole rasa and the others its transformations and variations. Nowhere is Abhinavagupta's theory of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa, the universalisation of emotion, better illustrated than in the third act: in the shadow-Sītā episode, Sītā is on stage but Rāma cannot see her, while the audience witnesses both characters' suffering simultaneously. This double vision is a theatrical mechanism of universalisation, lifting spectators beyond an individual's grief into the aesthetic experience of grief made general. In the language of dhvani, a line such as "Apūrvakarmacāṇḍālamayi mugdhe vimucyatām," in which Rāma calls himself a caṇḍāla, is filled with the suggestion of self-reproach. The question of aucitya is central: is it fitting for the exemplary Rāma, the Maryādā Puruṣottama, to weep? Bhavabhūti's response—"Vajrād api kaṭhorāṇi mṛdūni kusumād api," harder than thunderbolts, softer than flowers—reinterprets propriety by giving the extraordinary hero an ordinary human heart.

A Perspective from Western Theory

In Aristotelian terms, Uttararāmacaritam has been called one of the closest Indian counterparts to tragedy: it involves hamartia, the abandonment of an innocent wife in the name of royal duty; prolonged suffering; and a catharsis of pity and fear (eleos and phobos). Yet the reunion at the end prevents it from being a tragedy in the strict sense. In Western terms it is a tragicomedy, or a striking precursor of Shakespeare's late romances—particularly *The Winter's Tale*, with its innocent wife cast off, years of remorse and revival by means of art, through statue or play. The garbha-nāṭaka is an early, self-conscious use of metatheatre, centuries before the "Mousetrap" of Hamlet, and it goes further: the play within the play does not merely test the truth but rewrites it; art repairs reality. In a subaltern reading the episode of Śambūka cannot be bypassed: Rāma's killing of the Śūdra ascetic is not removed by Bhavabhūti but staged, with Śambūka appearing in a divine form and praising Rāma. Modern criticism may discern both the acknowledgement of the violence of the varṇa order and an uneasy purification of that violence. To a feminist reading, the shadow-Sītā becomes an enduring figure of the "present absence" of a woman: she speaks, yet is not heard.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The Maithili translation responds to the celebrated difficulty of Bhavabhūti's diction with a native vocabulary of compassion. Expressions such as nor (tears), hiya haharab (the heart shuddering) and chātī phāṭab (the chest splitting with grief) root his pathos in the land of sohars and samdaunis, the songs of birth and farewell. The linguistic identity of characters who speak Prakrit is retained. Ultimately Uttararāmacaritam is

a work of world drama that shows what comes after epic: after victory, pain. Maithili, a language of songs of separation, proves to be its natural second home.

Abhijñānaśākuntalam

Kālidāsa's Crowning Achievement in Drama

Introduction to the Work

"Kāvyeṣu nāṭakaṃ ramyaṃ tatra ramyā Śakuntalā"—among literary forms, drama is delightful, and among dramas Śakuntalā is beautiful. Such near-unanimity is rare in Sanskrit criticism. Kālidāsa transformed the stern story of Śakuntalā in the Mahābhārata—where Duṣyanta knowingly denies her—by introducing Durvāsas's curse and the ring as an instrument of recognition, or abhijñāna. The resulting seven-act play takes love through three stages: its natural flowering in the hermitage; a painful middle of forgetfulness and rejection in the royal court; and a reunion purified by austerity at Hemakūṭa. Nature is not a backdrop here but a character: at Śakuntalā's departure, trees give her clothing and a deer catches hold of her garment.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

From the standpoint of rasa, Śakuntalā completes the entire cycle of śṛṅgāra: union, separation and reunion. Its distinction lies in the fact that the cause of separation is not an external villain, but destiny in the form of a curse and the hero's own forgetting. The shade of karuṇa falling upon śṛṅgāra therefore becomes an exemplary blending of rasa. For the school of dhvani, Śakuntalā is familiar ground: Ānandavardhana and Abhinavagupta repeatedly draw examples from it. Kaṇva's farewell in the fourth act—"Pātuṃ na prathamaṃ vyavasyati jalam"—is so dense with the suggestion of parental tenderness that later criticism singled out that act as the jewel of the entire drama: "Kāvyeṣu nāṭakaṃ … tatrāpi ca caturtho 'ṅkaḥ." Seen through vakrokti, the token of recognition, the ring, constitutes an overarching obliqueness: proof of love is entrusted to an object, and then the object is lost. Kuntaka might have called this prakaraṇa-vakratā, obliqueness in the construction of an episode. Kālidāsa's restraint is unmatched by the criterion of aucitya: Duṣyanta is not rendered simply cruel in the scene of rejection; he is under a curse. The artistry of suffering without a straightforward villain is an extreme achievement of propriety. Bharata's dictum "Kāvyaṃ grāhyam alaṅkārāt" finds its fulfilment here in simile—the celebrated phrase "Alaṃ Kālidāsasya upamā" points to the distinction of Kālidāsa's comparisons.

A Perspective from Western Theory

Śakuntalā was among the first Indian literary works to enter Western literary consciousness. After reading Sir William Jones's 1789 translation, Goethe wrote that if heaven and earth were to be named together in a single word, one should say "Śakuntalā." The source reads the theatrical prelude to Goethe's *Faust* (*Vorspiel auf dem Theater*) as directly indebted to the sūtradhāra's introduction in Śakuntalā; it locates here one seed of Goethe's idea of world literature, or Weltliteratur. Romantic criticism found in the work a unity of nature and humanity. For contemporary ecocriticism, the forest hermitage is an ideal literary image of an ecological community in which human beings are members, not masters, of nature. A structuralist reading might regard the ring as a pure mechanism of Barthes's "hermeneutic code": the story is locked and unlocked by its loss and recovery. Feminist criticism speaks in two voices. On one side stands the silencing of Śakuntalā: in the court, her truthful testimony is deprived of evidentiary force, an all-too-familiar pattern of devaluing women's witness. On the other side, the bold Śakuntalā of the Mahābhārata, who rebukes the king in open court, appears softened in Kālidāsa's heroine. A more attentive reading, however, observes that Kālidāsa too gives Śakuntalā a sharp rebuke—"Anārya!"—in that courtroom scene. For psychoanalysis, Duṣyanta's forgetfulness can become a figure of repression: guilt about the social transgression of a Gandharva marriage swallows memory, and the ring, as material evidence, brings the repressed back into view.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

In the Maithili translation, Śakuntalā's forest hermitage becomes a flowering garden of Mithila. The soft Maithili vocabulary for creepers, bees and young deer corresponds to Kālidāsa's tenderness. A domestic level of Maithili for Śakuntalā's Prakrit-speaking companions and a higher register touched by Sanskrit for the passages in verse offer a creative answer to the Sanskrit–Prakrit division in the original. Taken as a whole, the Maithili incarnation of Śakuntalā performs the cultural work of building a bridge between Vidyāpati's language and Kālidāsa: the inseparability of love and nature is the common property of both poets.

Mudrārākṣasam (The Royal Seal of Minister Rākṣasa)

Viśākhadatta's Political Drama

Introduction to the Work

In the Sanskrit dramatic tradition, Mudrārākṣasam stands almost alone: there is no heroine, no erotic love, and no jester. The entire play is a game of chess between two minds. After the fall of the Nanda dynasty, Cāṇakya

has already placed Candragupta upon the throne; but his real objective is now not to destroy an enemy but to change his heart—to make Rākṣasa, the minister who remained loyal to the Nandas, a minister of Candragupta. Using a seal (mudrā), a forged letter, and a network of disguised spies, Cāṇakya turns every move by Rākṣasa into a position he has already prepared. In the final move, Rākṣasa's own virtue—his compassion in seeking to save his friend Candanadāsa—becomes the means of his 'defeat'. Viśākhadatta was a Kṣatriya prince: his knowledge of politics, the essay argues, came not from books but from the palace.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

From the standpoint of rasa, Mudrārākṣasam poses a problem for classical classification. Tradition regards vīra (the heroic) as its principal rasa; yet this is not the heroism of battle but that of strategy and intellect—nīti-vīra or buddhi-vīra. Its enduring emotion is enthusiasm, but the object of that enthusiasm is not the battlefield: it is political planning. The play thus creatively expands the limits of rasa theory. In terms of the arrangement of dramatic junctures (sandhi), as formulated in the Nāṭyaśāstra's theory of plot construction, Mudrārākṣasam is exemplary: from mukha and pratimukha to nirvahaṇa, every juncture is tightly organised, and not a single scene is purposeless. From the standpoint of dhvani, the play's richness of suggestion lies in dramatic irony: the spectators know Cāṇakya's trap, while Rākṣasa does not, so every utterance by Rākṣasa continually suggests a second meaning to the audience. Considered through aucitya, Viśākhadatta's daring lies in making the apparent 'villain' the moral centre of the play. Rākṣasa's fidelity to his former sovereign is so noble that the title itself bears his name. Cāṇakya wins, but the greatness belongs to Rākṣasa: this separation of victory from moral stature is a particularly subtle deployment of propriety.

A Perspective from Western Theory

In Western generic terms, Mudrārākṣasam is the dramatic form of political realism. A thousand years before Machiavelli's Il Principe, it stages a debate about ends and means that resembles a theatrical commentary on Kauṭilya's Arthaśāstra. Cāṇakya is the maker of Machiavelli's ideal 'new prince', with one difference: personal self-interest has no place in his objective. Once his purpose is accomplished, he ties up his topknot and looks towards withdrawal into forest life; this conjunction of power and renunciation is absent from the particular model of Western realism under comparison. In terms of genre, the play is an early mature form of the espionage thriller and the heist structure. Its network of intrigue may be compared to John le Carré's Cold War narratives: assumed identities, a double agent (Bhāgurāyaṇa), forged documents, and the 'mastermind's' plan unfolding point by point. Structurally, the drama rests upon binary

oppositions—intellect/heart, politics/loyalty, the seal (the abstract power of the state)/Candanadāsa (the affection of ordinary citizens)—and resolves them by the merging of opposites, when Rākṣasa accepts the ministry. New Historicism would read the play as a document of state discourse in the Gupta era: a narrative legitimising the making of empire, in which violence is minimised and the manufacture of consent—Rākṣasa's own consent—becomes the highest aim.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The Maithili translation announces its approach in the very title, 'The Royal Seal of Minister Rākṣasa', rendering the weight of mudrā through a native vocabulary. It carefully retains the double meanings of diplomatic dialogue, which are the lifeblood of the drama; the coded language of the espionage episodes also moves naturally in Maithili. Taken as a whole, Mudrārākṣasam shows that Sanskrit drama could create the theatre of severity as well as tenderness, of the mind as well as the heart—and that, even there, the ultimate victory is the heart's.

Mṛcchakaṭikam (The Little Clay Toy Cart)

Śūdraka's Ten-Act Prakaraṇa

Introduction to the Work

Mṛcchakaṭikam is the most 'worldly' of the great works of Sanskrit drama. King Śūdraka—the author named by tradition—leaves the royal palace and enters the streets and lanes of Ujjayinī. Here we meet Cārudatta, a generous merchant reduced to poverty; Vasantasenā, an intelligent courtesan; the masseur who becomes a Buddhist mendicant after a life of gambling; Śarvilaka, the thief who regards burglary as an art; and Śakāra, the king's brother-in-law, an enduring embodiment of stupidity and cruelty. Meanwhile, Āryaka's political revolution is gathering strength in the background. The 'clay cart' of the title, the toy belonging to Rohasena into which Vasantasenā puts her jewels, is the seminal symbol of the entire play: an encounter between clay and gold, poverty and love.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

Within the classification of dramatic forms, this is a prakaraṇa: its plot is invented, its characters belong to ordinary social life, and its heroine is a courtesan. In Bharata's arrangement, the prakaraṇa is regarded as inferior to the nāṭaka; but Śūdraka grants this supposedly 'lesser' form the epic dignity of a ten-act scope. In terms of rasa, Mṛcchakaṭikam is a laboratory of mixed emotions: śṛṅgāra (Cārudatta and Vasantasenā), hāsya (Maitreya and Śakāra), karuṇa (the journey to the place of execution), along with adbhuta, vīra and even bībhatsa. Remarkably, this crowding of rasas

produces no rupture of aesthetic experience, because of aucitya: each rasa is tied to the social standing and linguistic register of its characters. One of the richest uses of the Nāṭyaśāstra's language system appears here—seven or eight Prakrit varieties that make the social positions of the characters audible. From the perspective of vakrokti, Śakāra's 'inverted scholarship', his garbled references to the Rāmāyaṇa and Mahābhārata, is the oblique expression of ignorance, an inexhaustible resource of verbal comedy. From the standpoint of dhvani, the clay cart is an ideal instance of suggestion through an object: the jewels placed inside it become the seed of the plot's complications, while 'gold in clay' spreads a symbolic meaning associated with Cārudatta's impoverished generosity.

A Perspective from Western Theory

In Western genre classifications, Mṛcchakaṭikam possesses the full features of tragicomedy and melodrama: the execution of an innocent man is stopped at the last moment. Its deeper identity, however, is as a 'city comedy'. Twelve hundred years before Ben Jonson's London, it presents an extensive civic portrait of Ujjayinī's economy, administration of justice, and criminal underworld. For a Marxist reading, this is an especially fertile Sanskrit text: the circulation of property—the jewels passing from hand to hand—is the actual motor of the plot. The courtroom scene lays bare class justice: the poor person's testimony is treated as invalid. Āryaka's revolt makes this an exceptional Sanskrit drama in which a change of ruler is led by a cowherd's son, anticipating a subaltern view of history upon the stage. From a feminist perspective, Vasantasenā's story is an account of a courtesan's emancipation: she leaves the economy of her profession and gains the status of a bride. A modern reading may see two opposing meanings in this ending: a woman's victory, or her renewed subordination within the institution of marriage. From a Brechtian perspective, the courtroom farce and Śakāra's extravagantly theatrical manner themselves produce an 'alienation effect', obliging spectators to reflect upon the social order. It is worth remembering that German theatre has been staging this play since the nineteenth century.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

To meet the multilingual demands of the play, the Maithili translation, 'The Little Clay Toy Cart', draws on Maithili's own levels of speech: distinctly colloquial, everyday, and Sanskrit-enriched. Śakāra's corrupt utterances find an equivalent in Maithili's humorous distortions of expression, while Cārudatta's verse calls for a mature poetic register. The supposedly 'learned' description of theft and the scenes in the gambling house flourish particularly in Maithili idiom. Ultimately, Mṛcchakaṭikam proves that an Indian classic is a 'classic' not because it tells the stories of

kings and gods, but because it can fill a clay cart with the gold of humanity.

Bhagavadajjukam (The Ascetic and the Courtesan)

A Farce Attributed to Bodhāyana: The Comedy of Exchanged Souls

Introduction to the Work

Bhagavadajjukam is regarded as one of the most intellectually brilliant works in the Sanskrit tradition of farce. Its dramatic mechanism is astonishing. To demonstrate to his restless disciple Śāṇḍilya the yogic power of 'entering another body' (parakāya-praveśa), a wandering ascetic (the Bhagavān) enters the body of Vasantasenā (Ajjukā), a courtesan who has died because of a mistake by Yama's messenger. When that messenger tries to correct his error, he places the courtesan's soul in the ascetic's body. The result is Vedāntic speech issuing from a courtesan's body, and the gestures of erotic desire from that of a renunciant. Physician, mother and lover are all bewildered. Śāṇḍilya, the disciple driven by hunger who has fled a Buddhist monastery and become a 'slave to food', serves as both witness and comic facilitator of the chaos. Composed in the Pallava period (possibly contemporaneous with or earlier than Mahendravikrama), this farce survived alongside Mattavilāsa in the temple-theatre traditions of southern India, extending to Kūṭiyāṭṭam.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

In rasa terms, laughter arises here from the discrepancy between outward appearance and speech. Bharata includes 'distorted costume and ornament' among the causes (vibhāvas) of the comic; Bhagavadajjukam takes the distortion to a philosophical level. What is displaced is not the garment but the soul itself. From the standpoint of dhvani, the farce is exceptional because every moment of humour suggests a serious Vedāntic proposition: the distinction between body and self and the question 'Who am I?' (ko 'ham). What the Upaniṣads formulate solemnly, this farce displays in reverse: when bodies are exchanged, who is the 'I'? Philosophical disputation conducted under the pretext of comedy becomes a kind of 'satirical Vedānta'. From the perspective of vakrokti, the whole play rests upon one immense obliqueness of inversion. The question of aucitya is also fascinating: is this kind of mockery of an ascetic appropriate? The answer lies within the work. The satire is directed not at a genuine yogin—whose spiritual power is real—but at hypocrisy and the confusion of body with self. At the end, all souls regain their proper bodies; the restoration of order preserves dramatic propriety.

A Perspective from Western Theory

Within Western genre categories, the play's narrative mechanism offers one of the oldest fully developed examples of body-swap comedy in world literature. The convention extends into modern cinema, including works such as Freaky Friday; but whereas Western adaptations commonly teach lessons in psychological empathy, Bodhāyana raises a philosophical question: does identity reside in the body or in consciousness? The question directly engages modern philosophy of mind—Locke's memory theory and debates on personal identity—and stages it a millennium before Locke's celebrated thought experiment about the prince and the cobbler. Bakhtin's theory of the carnival is realised here almost literally: the exchange of high and low, ascetic and courtesan, is a central carnivalesque principle, while the centrality of the body resembles Bakhtin's material-bodily perspective. Bergson's formula for laughter, the mechanical imposed upon the living body, reaches an extreme form: the soul changes, but the body's habits do not. From an absurdist perspective, the 'clerical mistake' made by Yama's messenger—taking the wrong life—produces precisely the irony of cosmic administration familiar to readers of Kafka and Ionesco. Here destiny is not tragic; it is bureaucratic.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The Maithili title, 'The Ascetic and the Courtesan', immediately captures the play's structure of reversal. Its hardest translation problem is the exchange between the Sanskrit-laden voice of the renunciant inhabiting the courtesan's body and the sensuous speech of the courtesan inhabiting the renunciant's body. The distinction between Maithili's levels of expression—a register rich in tatsama words on one side and a lively popular idiom on the other—allows this reversal to work. The success of the translation resides in that linguistic crossing itself. In sum, Bhagavadajjukam shows that the gravest philosophical enquiry and the freest laughter are not antagonists in the Indian tradition: they are two sides of one coin. The question 'Who am I?' may be asked in the very midst of uproarious laughter.

Mattavilāsa-Prahasanam (The Farce of Intoxicated Delight)

A Farce by the Pallava King Mahendravikrama Varman

Introduction to the Work

At the beginning of the seventh century, the Pallava emperor of Kāñcī, Mahendravikrama Varman—known as 'Vicitracitta'—composed a farce that is a remarkable document of royal self-confidence: an exposure of the absurdities of the religious world of his own capital, Kāñcī. Satyasoma, a drunken Śaiva Kāpālika, loses his skull—his begging bowl, made from a

human cranium—and accuses the Buddhist monk Nāgasena of stealing it. A Pāśupata intervenes as mediator; the skull is recovered from a madman; and the quarrel subsides almost as suddenly as it arose. In this short, one-act work, the religious plurality of Kāñcī at the time—Kāpālikas, Buddhists, Pāśupatas, and references to Jains—is recorded at the level of street life.

A Perspective from Indian Poetics

From the standpoint of the Nāṭyaśāstra, Mattavilāsa is an exemplary instance of a 'pure farce' (śuddha prahasana): a disparaging imitation of hypocritical ascetics, servants and related figures. Yet the refinement that comes from the royal author is noteworthy. Coarse verbal abuse is relatively limited; humour of situation and character predominates. In the structure of rasa, the determinants of laughter associated with intoxication (mada) occupy the centre. Bharata identifies three stages of drunkenness, and Satyasoma's behaviour progressively exhibits them; the word 'intoxicated' (matta) appears in the very title. From a vakrokti perspective, the play's keenest weapon is specious reasoning: Satyasoma describes the tavern as a sacrificial hall—the flag becomes the sacrificial post, wine becomes soma, the drinking cup becomes the sacrificial vessel. This chain of comparisons simultaneously produces the ingenuity of oblique expression and suggests the hollowness of religious language. From the standpoint of dhvani, the Buddhist monk's private thought—'Which envious old man added the prohibition of wine and women to the Piṭaka texts?'—is an utterance pregnant with the satire of concealed desire. Viewed through aucitya, note the king's balance: no particular sect is favoured. Satire falls upon all alike and, therefore, upon none exclusively—an aesthetics of governmental impartiality.

A Perspective from Western Theory

In Western categories, Mattavilāsa possesses all the characteristics of farce: a missing object, false accusation, a public quarrel, and resolution by chance. A thousand years before Molière's Tartuffe, it staged religious hypocrisy. There is, however, a decisive difference: Molière's satirical figure is a conscious deceiver, while Satyasoma is not a deceiver but a sincere fool —he believes what he says. That distinction saves the satire from cruelty and keeps it within the domain of Bergson's 'mechanisation of habit'. From Bakhtin's perspective, Mattavilāsa literally stages the carnival: wine, the street, the profanation of the sacred (the skull-bowl!), and the 'emperor's own carnival'. Royal authority itself mocks the religious authorities of its city. New Historicism would ask whether this mockery is subversive or instead a safety valve sanctioned by power (licensed misrule). Probably the latter: by permitting laughter, the king also displays his mastery over religious institutions. From a sociological perspective on

religion, the play pictures a 'marketplace' of sectarian competition, an economy of alms, vessels and reputation. The disappearance of the skull is thus a story of the theft of symbolic capital, in Bourdieu's sense: without his skull, a Kāpālika loses his very identity.

Assessment of the Translation and Conclusion

The Maithili title, 'The Farce of Intoxicated Delight', brings out the original pun in matta: drunken and carried away by delight. To represent the stumbling speech of intoxication, the translation draws accurately on the familiar folk rhythms of Maithili drunken talk. It preserves the sacrificial terminology in the series of comparisons between tavern and sacrificial hall, which is essential to the edge of the satire. Ultimately, Mattavilāsa is that rare work in which the throne itself descends into the street and laughs. A millennium and a half later, the laughter remains fresh, for hypocrisy never grows old.

23. Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’s’ Children's Story ‘Māṭik Bāsan’ (Clay Vessels)

Abstract

Māṭik Bāsan was published electronically in Videha and collected in Videha: Sadeha 32 (pp. 2–5), available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm. Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’: village/post office, Haripur Dih Tol, Madhubani. Kedar Prasad is a skilled potter of the village.

Keywords: Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’ · Māṭik Bāsan · children’s story · potters’ tradition · sculpture · plot · folk culture

Māṭik Bāsan (Clay Vessels)

An Examination of the Story

Positive Aspects of the Story

Negative Aspects of the Story

A long children’s story—or, if one prefers, a novel—by Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’, entitled Chonaha, was published in Videha. It was subsequently collected in Videha: Sadeha 9 (Videha Children’s Festival, pp. 109–126), and is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm. This is the first Maithili work founded on child psychology. The novel ought to be included in a training course on how to write children’s literature in Maithili: it shows how a modern novel progresses, step by step, and how this works in the case of a children’s novel. I urge you at least to read it.

But in Māṭik Bāsan, Jagadanand disappointed me. I had expected something like Pedinti Ashok Kumar’s Jigri; instead, what I found was something as ordinary as Shivshankar Srinivas’s Pandit O Hunak Putra (The Pandit and His Son).

It is true that Māṭik Bāsan is a children’s vihani tale, a seed-story. Yet a writer with the plot—

“People began using steel and other metals instead of clay vessels”—

should not end the story with—

“But my dream— — — will no longer come true.” Saying this, he walked out of the room.

I cannot accept this. Thus an extraordinary plot has remained merely a good but mediocre story.

Analysis

This story needs to be developed further. That could be done by increasing its length, but the subject could equally be developed within the existing word count. The author has strayed from his objective: he failed to develop the proposition that "people began using steel and other metals instead of clay vessels." I had not expected this from the author of Chonaha. He will have to rewrite the story, whether it remains a vihani tale, becomes a short story or a longer story, or even grows into a novel.

24. Why Should Readers Read My Books?

Abstract

The first question is this: we have heard that a work is good, but how are we to obtain the book? Earlier, postage on books sent to Nepal was the same as postage within India; now postage costs more than the book or magazine itself, so Maithili books no longer reach Nepal. If I live in New Jersey and cannot find Maithili books and periodicals in Madhubani or Darbhanga, where will I find them in Uganda, the USA or Australia?

Keywords: Gajendra Thakur · literary works · poetry · ghazals · stories · novels · drama · reader reception

The first question is this: we have heard that a work is good, but how are we to obtain the book? Earlier, postage on books sent to Nepal was the same as postage within India; now postage costs more than the book or magazine itself, so Maithili books no longer reach Nepal. If I live in New Jersey and cannot find Maithili books and periodicals in Madhubani or Darbhanga, where will I find them in Uganda, the USA or Australia? For this reason I tell you that all my works are available on the internet at http://videha.co.in/new_page_90.htm. This amounts to declaring the end of geographical boundaries, and availability is no longer limited by the number of copies in stock.

I shall now describe my books under the following categories:

Original Works

Verse (general poetry, lyrical narratives, ghazals, and poems and ghazals for children)

Prose (general stories, novels, criticism, essays, treatises, drama, editorials, and children's literature)

Translations

Prose — my translations of general stories and children's literature

Verse — my translations of poetry

Let us turn first to poetry. Uday Narayan Singh quoted several of my poems, which he liked. I reproduce his analysis below:

"Several lines may well remain engraved upon the reader's mind, such as:

> "The wall of collapsing emotions
> A pillar of frailty stands upright
> The granary of longing is filled

Standing as a symbol
The shrine of Himalayan wood kept inside the house, or
The tulsi plant standing on the veranda
Only a symbol of fellow feeling."

Or consider the following lines:

"The visible scene of a listening void
On nature's canvas
The picture of a roaring sea
The words of a figure painted in a dark cavern
No one will see these pictures of mine in the darkness
Will anyone, then, even hear the voice of the figure's longing?"

The influence of numerous cultures, not only of Mithila but of India more widely, can be seen in his fiction and poetry. This extends the horizon of active literary creation in Maithili, bringing fresh images, sounds and plots into view.

What Mandākinī is the poet seeking when he says:

"The Mandākinī that was in the midst of the sky
I saw upon the earth today..."

The imprint of his extensive travels is clearly discernible in his writing. One other thing is evident: Gajendra Thakur the lexicographer and Gajendra Thakur the creative writer are different persons, different even in temperament. In his lexicographical work, the figure of the editor and the person concerned with technology is unmistakable, but in the moment of artistic creation all these aspects disappear.

In many works one finds not merely rounded narratives but political commentary as well. He shows no hesitation in writing it. Consider the many great warriors of Kurukshetra: each was a renowned expert in his own field and discipline—some in commanding armies of several akṣauhiṇīs, others in archery, and so on. All knew the difference between dharma and adharma, yet each seemed helpless before the impending catastrophe. Such situations can be glimpsed in stories and interpretations even in the present context. I would call this a strength of the great text, or metatext. Otherwise, why would he write:

Watching the countrymen fall behind
Awakened in a noon filled with spells and charms
A dream of murmured incantations
Becomes the swiftest runner
The most nimble wrestler in the arena
The labouring master's voice breaks his solitude
The sleep of a night painted black with soot

The sequence of sleep and dreams—breaking, returning, breaking
...

We may regard this great text as an experiment; equally, we may see it as a distillation of the circle of the Seven Sages, or as a modern epic divided into seven kāṇḍas."

Rajdev Mandal writes:

"Sitting at the chessboard of the millennium, you are watching the game of life. Through deep exploration you create one image after another and immerse yourself in that exhilaration.

A scene beside the boundless sea
The heart brimming with exhilaration...

The poet within you evokes the image of the sun and says:

"The rays of the sun had spread across
How many mysteries vanished
The mist of darkness has grown fearful
But what is this...?

I had the welcome opportunity to read a few haiku in the collection, for a change of taste. Your poems carry the fragrance of Mithila into all our minds:

"I remember the paddy fields
Jhilli and kachauri
Gathering bundles of harvested paddy
With the money from gleaned ears of grain we bought
Red sparklers
Which were called red sticks, and
Played sat-dhariyā..."

While living away from home, one remembers one's village and household. These lines express the pain of separation, together with a new rhythm:

"I do not know whether I shall ever return
Or whether I shall die and fade away
Here..."

The satire is clearly visible in these lines:

"No delay at all in striking with the stick
Nor much sorrow when a heifer is born
Yet you are worthy of worship..."

The problem created by flooding, compressed into a handful of short lines, is an attempt to contain an ocean in a pitcher, as these lines reveal:

"The earthen ridges were breached here and there

And rain kept falling from above
All the paddy and rice stored in earthen bins
The screens collapsed, becoming prey to the water...”

The poems are filled with ever-new images:

“Monstrous as a thousand floods
A tangle of happenings
My breath grew laboured
I sprang up in alarm...”

You did not merely spring up in alarm; you rose with awareness, bearing new images and sounds and a fresh vision. I cannot tell how far you will go, or where your destination lies.

“In the churning of the world
Something new will now emerge...
We shall seek the way along the road...
The journey has now grown long...””

All these poems can be found in my book Sahasrābdīk Cauparpar (On the Chessboard of the Millennium).

I now present two poems from my book Sahasrajit.

The Evil Eye Falls

Mother says
That the evil eye may fall on someone.
And it is true! Who else has a son like mine?
Whenever he begins a task,
He takes on a heap of work at once.
Until it is finished, he thinks of nothing else.
And Mother's heart misses a beat;
Her heart begins to sink.
What is he doing?
What is so beautiful about him?
Yet Mother goes on saying
That the evil eye can fall
On my son at every turn.
The daughter-in-law speaks to her mother-in-law,
And a smile comes to Mother's face.

Kaṭihārī

I
There is a biting chill in the wind.
This cold will penetrate the bones.
They laid it down below,
Dipping it into the icy water.
Taking fire from a cow-dung-cake hearth,
To give the body its final passage,
They consigned it to the flames,
Together with grass, wood and ghee.
Everyone will return.
They are all returning home.
But there is no difference.
Look at the condition of the woman:
More piercing than this freezing wind,
It enters the bones.
Not on the bank of the Kamala, but beside the Yamuna,
A thousand miles from the village,
The same story as sixty years ago,
The same society.
Only the clothes have changed;
Only the course of the river has changed.

That body was laid upon seven stone slabs;
Fire devours it, roaring as it burns.
A family must be built anew, once again.

2
Kuśa grass spread on the ground near the tulsi plant,
Facing north;
A body subjected to a post-mortem examination.
After circling the dead three times,
They offer fire to the mouth.
The deceased, in dove-white attire;
Each person offers five pieces of wood.
Severing all seven bonds,
Throwing the seven satkaṭhiyā sticks into the fire,
Placing children and elders in front,
Stepping carefully, protecting their heels,
They go to bathe.
They offer tila-anjali with moṛā, sesame and water,
Without wiping their bodies dry,
Then, in the courtyard of the deceased,
They touch the ground and return home.

My Ghazal

Om Prakash Jha writes:

"Of course, all the poets who compose ghazals for children are capable of doing so and are writing very fine children's ghazals. In this context, however, I consider it appropriate to mention a children's ghazal by Shri Gajendra Thakur. The opening couplet of one of his children's ghazals is:

Leave the bride-and-bridegroom dolls; bring Barbie.
If the colour is pink, recognise Barbie.

Read the entire ghazal and see for yourself. By invoking the traditional bride-and-bridegroom dolls, this ghazal entertains young children; at the same time it offers a moving reflection on humanity sacrificed upon the altar of today's consumerism."

He writes about this composition:

Children's Ghazal

Leave the bride-and-bridegroom dolls; bring Barbie.
If the colour is pink, recognise Barbie.
The demons who roam from forest to forest—
Imagine Barbie returning with Vanasapto.

At daybreak, bearing seven colours into the village,
A fairy dwells there; listen, Barbie.
Let the shivering among children cease;
Forget the tear-filled eyes, resolve, Barbie.
Wander through water, sky and earth,
Put on wings; heed the little forehead-mark, Barbie.
Play and leap with the dhamm doll;
Dream at night and bring sleep, Barbie.
Put this doll to bed, and go to sleep;
Ride Airāvata and sing of the day, Barbie.

This is included in my ghazal collection Dhāṅgi Bāṭ Banebāk Dām Agūbār Pene Chhaṅ (roughly a hundred pages), in which ghazals occupy forty pages and a study of Maithili ghazal poetics occupies sixty. The book is titled Dhāṅgi Bāṭ Banebāk Dām Agūbār Pene Chhaṅ.

I present here the title ghazal from that book:

A traveller on the bitter path of love since time immemorial,
Carried that aged love in both hands.
With pure fingers, touching its puthpurī,
It spreads farphaisī when the agilkaṇṭha is merciless.
That love, nimarjanā, once beat with unblemished purity;
For the lover's anguish, it was a taut, harsh bow.
Knowing no distinction between an unworthy act and duty,
It never concealed the burning story of love.
The khanja-khūhar Airāvata is no path upon the path;
I have been paid in advance for making the dhāṅgi road.

In an interview with me, Munna Ji asked the following question. The interview is available in Videha: Sadeha, no. 33, p. 415; I reproduce an extract here.

Munnaji: Despite all the work you have done, neither your personality nor your writings have yet received a proper assessment. Does that not affect you?

Gajendra Thakur: No, I do not agree. The emails and letters I have received, readers' appreciations, the success of my project to preserve manuscripts, and my research in linguistics have all given me satisfaction. How could people of ill will also speak well of you? I would not even wish for that. In Maithili, as in other languages, an assessment of a person's life and work comes only after death.

The mind has become as pure as the water of the Ganges;
The Lord follows behind, calling, "Kabir, Kabir."
(Kabir)

(The mind has grown as pure as the Ganges; the Lord himself follows behind, calling "Kabir, Kabir." — Kabir)

The khanja-khūhar Airāvata is no path upon the path;
I have been paid in advance for making the dhāṅgi road.
(Others receive payment after their work is done; I have been paid in advance.)

Jagadanand Jha "Manu" writes: "Gajendra Thakur's observation is entirely right: the more childlike a person can become, the better the children's ghazal that person will write."

Chandan Kumar Jha writes: "Gajendra Ji not only wrote ghazals while strengthening the grammar of the ghazal; in the forms of a simple syllabic metre and a simple quantitative metre, he gave the Maithili ghazal world two invaluable baḥrs, or metrical structures. For many younger poets and beginners like us, they have proved helpful in composing ghazals. This is bringing an unprecedented enrichment to the Maithili ghazal."

Ashish Anchinhar writes:

"Recently, however, Gajendra Thakur successfully composed a ghazal in baḥr-e-mutaqārib. It has therefore become necessary to discuss it. In fact, the discovery of a syllabic baḥr in Maithili was also made by Gajendra Thakur, and almost every new ghazal poet is following that example."

That ghazal is given below.

Baḥr-e-Mutaqārib

Baḥr-e-mutaqārib: eight rukns; faʿūlun (U | |), repeated four times.

You take me for a gambler, for no reason;
Why speak of a peculiar way of living, for no reason?
I raised a clamour; I sang my sadness away;
Why do you coax the conjurer, for no reason?
Whatever nabārī and chabārī there are, they burn;
No one comes back to turn the sutārī, for no reason.
Hungry within the home, disappointed outside,
Crying in famine, helpless, for no reason.
We walk, bearing the palanquin, sustained by this hope;
The bhāsāṭhī approaches; you ponder, for no reason.
Even what has been seen and known comes today;
The lamp of protection is being extinguished.
What shall I tell anyone, and who will believe it?
In every recess—meaning that there is so much.
Why do you refuse to listen without even hearing the matter?
Hate it, if hatred is all that fills you.
A thick line of anxiety across the forehead;
It was small, and now it has grown chhebgar.
Amid the blazing fire of aspiration,
I called it the sign that I had grown great.
Today's matter will come to an end, you know;
The morning breeze has turned into a birro.
Ask everyone; leave no one out.
Why was the new dawn held back?
The breeze that quietly broke into a sob;
Having found love, it has become khaṭbatāh.
To be clever has turned into counterfeit knowledge;
The bhaukī keeps snapping at khikhir every moment.
The performer laughs, turned into a bipṭā;
You too have seen it, just as I have.
I have bathed at the ghāṭ of fear;
And so I shall endure oppression from every direction.
The hare spoke of this pirauñch light;
It stands in the middle of the road; I could not stop it.
Strike them down; cast away the thoughts of the mind;
When things cleared, they went out of control.
Crocodiles have arrived in our neighbourhood;
Water burial has become a business.

Airāvata is not the gaja-grāhaka elephant;
A way of bringing the two together has appeared.
My eyes are closing; tell me what I should do;
I cannot understand; anger rises—tell me what to do.
Here the paddy has turned into empty husk;
A green fire smoulders—tell me what I should do.
A moment of experience, seen and touched;
Will these lines not become history?
Lost along the road, why will you not linger for me?
The flowing current of lies has come to a halt;
When it flows backward, it burns again and again.
Even Lachhano has inherited her father's stubbornness;
Forgetting good and bad, we have become just the same.
The little bird was instructed in this way;
The well-wisher says, "What a formidable hunter!"
At daybreak, sadness was flying away;
I fashioned this charako pariyāṇi many times.
I wait for the path of deliverance, yet I am called the sun;
What remains for the solitary one? Not a single thing.
I rise even in darkness and count and count;
When shall I inscribe my own new form anew?
When shall I make the north–south thoroughfare flow?
The floor will remain shivering with cold, sir;
When will you taste it if you go on yearning?
If somewhere fate weeps over migration,
It is because of the habit of enduring pain.
A knot forms, and that too begins to look beautiful;
I had not understood that the matter had grown so large.
Today I saw that it was sinking;
How much, and what, it used to ask of me, again and again!
It is leaving without taking what had accumulated;
It is leaving without hearing what I have to say.

Like the vihani tale, this form is not regarded as serious. But if the compositions that follow (from my book Sahasrajit) seem serious to you, then you may take it that my work has succeeded.

1

Nature's Wrath

With kuśa grass, sesame, and water,
becoming a widow—
what distinction from a woman whose husband lives?
Dūb grass, unbroken rice, and water. (Tanka/Waka)
From the oleander,
house, trees, and mountains
are encircled. (Haiku)
The people of the forest
cannot forget
the water flowing by their homes. (Senryū)
I am playing
in the dark jhummari;
the sky is below.
Today the house is only an outline;
I am in the marshland.
(Haibun)

2

1.
Pursuing nature,
I have crossed to the other side—
a dried leaf.
(Haiku)

2.
These flowers and fruits
go on advancing;
their number decreases.
Turn and look again:
fewer nearby, more at a distance.
(Tanka/Waka)

3.
The colour has faded
from mountain and tree—
yet life remains.
(Senryū)

4.
The tree has become
a solitary child;
its leaves have become
nature's toys.

Look at the summit,
but do not stand still.
Come, let us return;
we are travellers,
we are among people,
going out and returning.
(Haibun)

3

4

Waiting upon the road,
look towards the sky:
a strange delusion,
as though this water-absorber
would rise and open a path.
Seven-coloured
is this hope;
hope rises,
the sky ready to sink—
and hope has become dread.

And now, kuṇḍaliyā verses (from my book Sahasrajit).

Kuṇḍaliyā

1

Distinguish truth from falsehood; harbour no obstruction.
Do not vacillate, not even a little, over what fate has written.
What fate has written—how can one simply call it good?
Truth will triumph, if you act without the crookedness of falsehood.
With falsehood comes fear; pull down the fear lodged in the heart.
Airāvat understands: this is the truth concealed in untruth.

2

The canopy turned and rustled with leaves; day grew dark.
Returning home after the day was spent, time became dreadful.
Time became dreadful; every limb trembled.
Who would hear the question? Words were caught in the snare of speech.
Airāvat is distraught: where have words disappeared?
Whirling into time itself, one enters the hornets' nest.

3

If there is victory without pride, recognise that as good.
Do not panic at defeat; understand this, my friend.
Understand this, my friend: should a quarrel arise,

accept the loss and move ahead; do not make another uproar.
Where a deed has brought contentment, that alone is worthwhile.
Understand, O Airāvat, and contemplate defeat and victory.

4

Let speech be gracious; understand before speaking.
When the net is vast, silence may be the wiser course.
When the net is vast, it may swallow you at once.
A clamour will arise if the moment is not right.
Listen to what I say: words are precious.
Airāvat says: do not utter words as empty as an elephant's yam.

Now read the Flag Song of Mithila (from Sahasrābdīk Caupaṛpar).

The Flag Song of Mithila

Mithila's flag shall fly across the world;
I have seen Mother angered, adorned and stained;
I am restless, and my mind sinks in distress.
I come from a land of learning, industry and action;
your descendants shall return to prevail;
with intelligence, resourcefulness and courage,
do not doubt their capacity for victory.
Even if Maithili has grown faint of breath,
I shall appeal in the speech of conjunct letters;
our touch shall bring phonemes bursting forth—
the flag shall not fall, O Mother Mithila.
(Using Vidyāpati's vocabulary.)

Now learn the calls of animals and birds through this children's song (from Bāṅk Baṅaurā).

The bullock is threshing, you know!
Elephant: agatt, pichū, thāit, māil biri;
hīrr-hīrr, pig, come home with us;
tī-tī, the pigeon has flown up above;
lih-lih, goat, eat your grass.
The bullock is threshing, you know!
Atū, hen; kut-kut, doggy;
catty, pisū-pisū, will you come?
Hearing chehai-chehai, the young buffalo ran away;
I too shall flee and look for another path.
Arr, goat, eat your grass!
The bullock is threshing, you know!
Do not provoke it with dhēhai-dhēhai;

the bull will come to the threshing ground;
come here, hey, haure hau!
The bullock is threshing, you know!

And now a vihani tale.

If all you have read under the name of vihani tales are little comic anecdotes, this genre will not seem serious to you. So read a vihani tale from Galpa Guccha; read it more than once if necessary. I believe that, as with haiku and haibun, you will begin to take this form seriously too.

Polygamous Marriage and the Hijra

"Poor woman, she has died," the villagers said when Fulana Babu's third wife died.

"Fulana Babu has cut his third wife's throat," said one person.

"You speak the truth. When his first wife had no child, he married a second time. But when the second also had no child, he ought to have understood, shouldn't he?" said another.

"Yes, and instead he kept telling his third wife that God had not given them a child because she would not acknowledge his nephews. Imagine that!" said the third person.

"That damned hijra!" said the fourth, bringing the gathering to an end.

But this grand assembly of four people was united in its view that the first two marriages had been entirely proper.

My Novels

In his essay "The Representation of Dalit Characters in Maithili Novel Literature," Shiv Kumar Jha "Tillu" writes:

"In Gajendra Thakur's Sahasrabāṛhani, an indigenous person brings a medicinal root for asthma, but a few years later that root can no longer be found in the forest—a sign of the decline of the forests. His Sahasraśīrṣā, meanwhile, offers a detailed account of almost all the Dalit communities of Mithila. Although it has only three houses, the Dhobiya Toli has come to constitute a distinct hamlet. Clothes belonging to Marwari families are brought here for washing from as far away as Jhanjharpur. Those Mahiswar Brahmins who set off for wedding processions with their bell-bottoms on, whistling as they go, are not wearing their own clothes. These are the very garments of wealthy Marwaris, obtained on loan. The washerman rents out the Marwaris' clothes to them for two days. Korail Budhan and Domi Safi are washermen. Domi Safi is now Domi Das, because he follows the Kabirpanth. There is another hamlet, the Chamar Toli: the Chamars

Mukdev Ram and Kapildev Ram. It used to lie outside the village, beyond the bamboo grove. Now all the bamboo has been cut down and uprooted; the expanding settlement has reached the Chamar Toli. House plots and brick kilns lie side by side. Their assistance is expected in everything from beating drums to sounding ceremonial horns. When cattle die, the household continues to be regarded as ritually polluted until these people carry the carcass away. Bhola Paswan and Mukesh Paswan are Dusadhs, relatives of Gena Hazari's lower branch. This is the same Gena Hazari who saw a cow come and give milk upon a stalk of kuśa grass at Kusheshwar Sthan. He began to dig at the spot, and Mahadeva appeared deeper and deeper beneath the earth. The Mahadeva installed by Sita's son Kusha was thus discovered by Gena Hazari.

Mukesh Paswan's daughter Malati is a bank officer, and his son-in-law Mathuranand is principal of a D.P.S. school. They live in a farmhouse near Vasant Kunj. Bhola Paswan and Mukesh Paswan continue to live in the village.

During the famine of 1967, when all the ponds and depressions had dried up but Dakahi pond had not, the Prime Minister visited. People showed him how the Musahars dug out bisāṛh roots there to eat. Umesh, the son of the leatherworker Mukdev Ram, has spread out his implements next to that open-air barber's salon, although he lives in Kishangarh. Besides repairing sandals and shoes, he has learned to make duplicate keys for locks. If you have the key, a duplicate costs fifteen rupees. If the key has been lost, a replacement costs one hundred rupees. Calling him to the house costs another two hundred rupees. Raghuvir, son of the Musahar Bichkun Saday, has learned driving. He drives for a businessman in Vasant Kunj and lives in Kishangarh. Shrimant, son of Baudha Mallik of the Dom Toli, has taken a maintenance contract for a sector. He employs two hundred people who collect the rubbish from residential quarters and clean roads and parking areas early every morning. Some of them, particularly people from Nepal, also wipe household windowpanes early in the morning for a monthly fee of two hundred rupees and have become newspaper hawkers. They live in Kishangarh; the Musahar Bichkun Saday, however, lives there in a house of his own."

Durganand Mandal writes:

"The affection of Shri Gajendra Thakur, editor of Videha, has awakened creative energy within me. There were many words that had not been used in Maithili literature and were called merely theth, or vernacular. When I read and came to know Thakur's book Kurukṣetram Antarmanak, my confidence in these words grew still stronger."

Rajendra Kumar Pradhan writes:

"Shri Gajendra Thakur's novel Sahasrabāṛhani bears witness to numerous political and bureaucratic upheavals. His Sahasraśīrṣā is a remarkably successful attempt to spread political consciousness through songs sung by Mohan, a Dalit singer, from India's independence to the Right to Information. Interwoven with it are the politics of the village and of floods, extending from the village all the way to Delhi."

In a novel-trilogy set in the fictional Mithila village of Garh Narikel, the second novel after Sahasraśīrṣā is also being published serially in electronic form on Videha.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal writes: "The minute geographical description of village life in Sahasrabāṛhani astonished me."

Umesh Mandal writes:

"Every letter of Gajendra Thakur's novel Sahasrabāṛhani resonates with a note of sensitivity. Its moving depiction of the images of feeling, imbued with exalted and considered economic understanding, presents the agitated suffering of Nand, a conscientious and honest man, as he fulfils both his household duties and his social responsibilities."

Sahasrabāṛhani (novel)

Sahasraśīrṣā (novel)

Short Fiction

Read "Sar-Samāj" and "Bāṇavīr" in Galpa Guccha (a collection of vihani tales and short stories).

Read "Siddha Mahāvīra," "Śabdaśāstram," "Delhi" and "Taskar" in Śabdaśāstram (a short-story collection).

Yoganand Jha writes:

"Kurukṣetram Antarmanak is a collection of Shri Gajendra Thakur's writings in various genres. Its seventh volume contains twenty-three stories for children. Most are accounts of the folk heroes of Mithila, although about half a dozen may be called children's folktales; even their language, however, is entirely classical in character. The work may be regarded as an important example of ongoing efforts to collect children's folktales."

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes:

"Gajendra Thakur is an extraordinary person, gifted with keen intellect and tremendous energy. His talent has a remarkably wide range. He works wholeheartedly for the advancement of language, literature and society.

Gajendra Thakur is multilingual. This quality is reflected in his dictionary-making, translations between several languages and various kinds of research. He is the founder of Videha, the first Maithili electronic magazine. Videha has provided Maithili with a global platform. To preserve and develop Maithil culture, he has built an extraordinary archive that continues to grow. Published in seven volumes, Kurukṣetram Antarmanak is a garden of Gajendra Thakur's creativity and intellectual inquiry. No literary genre seems to have escaped him. His multicoloured literary world is lucid and dedicated to the public good. In children's literature, the height and refinement of his art are without parallel."

o

The Year Forty-Seven...

A Village in Mithila...

My Plays

Ulkāmukh

Ulkāmukh (play)

Maithili Critical Theory

(For theory)

(For application)

Videha: Sadeha 33, pp. 201–206)

Maithili Ghazal Poetics

Vidyāpati's Bidesiyā

Videha: Sadeha 33, pp. 192–198

Munnaji: How long will you be able to sustain your firm resolve to stand your ground, despite abuse and vilification, in order to prevent Maithili journalism from being pushed aside—or in the pursuit of truth?

Gajendra Thakur: In the dedication to Kurukṣetram Antarmanak, I wrote:

> I had seen my father receiving truth with steadfast equanimity;
> from that very moment I had understood
> that there could be no renunciation:
> this path was the path of stubborn resolve.

Many people in my village began to weep on reading those lines. They know what they mean; to you, however, I can only say that the future will decide.

25. Sajhiyā Ropani (edited by Dr Pramod Kumar): A Review of the Collective Anthology of Bīhani Stories by Forty-Three Authors

Abstract

The shared bīhani-story anthology Sajhiyā Ropani brings together forty-three bīhani-story writers: 1. Ghanshyam Ghanero, 2. Munnaji, 3. Narayanji, 4. Pramod Kumar Jha "Gokul", 5. Dr Pramod Kumar, 6. Munni Kamat, 7. Amaresh Kumar Labh, 8. Vidya Chandra Jha "Bambam", 9. Satyendra Karna, 10. Bindeshwar Thakur, 11. Abha Jha, 12. Shiv Kumar, 13. Priyamvada, 14. Mahakant Prasad, 15. Prabhas Akinchan, 16. Ashish Anchinhar, 17. Poonam Jha, 18. Shubhra Santosh, 19. Jawahar Lal Kashyap, 20. Subhash Kumar Kamat, 21. Neeraj Karna, 22. Kumari Aarti, 23. Kalpana Jha–1 (Bokaro), 24. Kalpana Jha–2 (Patna), 25. Sabita Jha "Soni", 26. Vinita Thakur, 27. Mrinal Ashutosh, 28. Amar Thakur, 29. Manisha Jha, 30. Ruby Jha, 31. Om Prakash Jha, 32. Himadri Mishra "Him", 33. Ira Mallick, 34. Kanchan Kanth, 35. Rajesh Verma "Bhavaditya", 36. Misida, 37. Jayanti Kumari, 38. Kalpana Kumari, 39. Santwana Mishra, 40. Nandini Jha, 41. Bhuvaneshwar Chaurasia "Bhunesh", 42. Amar Kant Lal, 43. Deepa Mishra.

Keywords: Sajhiyā Ropani · bīhani story · Pramod Kumar · microfiction · subject matter · language · women's writing · anthology review

I

The shared bīhani-story anthology Sajhiyā Ropani brings together forty-three bīhani-story writers: 1. Ghanshyam Ghanero, 2. Munnaji, 3. Narayanji, 4. Pramod Kumar Jha "Gokul", 5. Dr Pramod Kumar, 6. Munni Kamat, 7. Amaresh Kumar Labh, 8. Vidya Chandra Jha "Bambam", 9. Satyendra Karna, 10. Bindeshwar Thakur, 11. Abha Jha, 12. Shiv Kumar, 13. Priyamvada, 14. Mahakant Prasad, 15. Prabhas Akinchan, 16. Ashish Anchinhar, 17. Poonam Jha, 18. Shubhra Santosh, 19. Jawahar Lal Kashyap, 20. Subhash Kumar Kamat, 21. Neeraj Karna, 22. Kumari Aarti, 23. Kalpana Jha–1 (Bokaro), 24. Kalpana Jha–2 (Patna), 25. Sabita Jha "Soni", 26. Vinita Thakur, 27. Mrinal Ashutosh, 28. Amar Thakur, 29. Manisha Jha, 30. Ruby Jha, 31. Om Prakash Jha, 32. Himadri Mishra "Him", 33. Ira Mallick, 34. Kanchan Kanth, 35. Rajesh Verma "Bhavaditya", 36. Misida, 37. Jayanti Kumari, 38. Kalpana Kumari, 39. Santwana Mishra, 40. Nandini Jha, 41. Bhuvaneshwar Chaurasia "Bhunesh", 42. Amar Kant Lal, 43. Deepa Mishra. This collection contains the work of twenty-three men and twenty women.

Male Bīhani-Story Writers in the Collection

1. Ghanshyam Ghanero, 2. Munnaji, 3. Narayanji, 4. Pramod Kumar Jha "Gokul", 5. Dr Pramod Kumar, 6. Amaresh Kumar Labh, 7. Vidya Chandra Jha "Bambam", 8. Satyendra Karna, 9. Bindeshwar Thakur, 10. Shiv Kumar, 11. Mahakant Prasad, 12. Prabhas Akinchan, 13. Ashish Anchinhar, 14. Jawahar Lal Kashyap, 15. Subhash Kumar Kamat, 16. Neeraj Karna, 17. Mrinal Ashutosh, 18. Amar Thakur, 19. Om Prakash Jha, 20. Rajesh Verma "Bhavaditya", 21. Misida, 22. Bhuvaneshwar Chaurasia "Bhunesh", 23. Amar Kant Lal.

Women Bīhani-Story Writers in the Collection

1. Munni Kamat, 2. Abha Jha, 3. Priyamvada, 4. Poonam Jha, 5. Shubhra Santosh, 6. Kumari Aarti, 7. Kalpana Jha–1 (Bokaro), 8. Kalpana Jha–2 (Patna), 9. Sabita Jha "Soni", 10. Vinita Thakur, 11. Manisha Jha, 12. Ruby Jha, 13. Himadri Mishra "Him", 14. Ira Mallick, 15. Kanchan Kanth, 16. Jayanti Kumari, 17. Kalpana Kumari, 18. Santwana Mishra, 19. Nandini Jha, 20. Deepa Mishra.

The number of women writing bīhani stories is heartening. For that reason, the editor's impartial outlook deserves praise. That an editor should remain impartial is still treated almost as a special virtue in Maithili —a distressing state of affairs, certainly.

2

Forty-three authors have undertaken this shared planting of eighty-six bīhani stories.

Ghanshyam Ghanero's "Achhop" is caustic, whether or not it is aimed at the editorial effort to prop Maithili up and keep it standing; Munnaji's "Focus!" is both sharp and sweet-and-sour. Narayanji's "Kushal" portrays human nature in much the same way as Rajmohan Jha's bīhani story "Chalah" (see the 67th Videha special issue devoted to bīhani stories: https://videha123.files.wordpress.com/2010/10/videha_01_10_2010.pdf), and both have the same plot. This demonstrates that a bīhani story, too, has a plot, and that two quite different bīhani stories can be written around one plot. Pramod Kumar Jha "Gokul" creates embellished, classical scenes in his bīhani stories; those who say that the miniature form cannot accommodate such effects are thereby proved wrong. Dr Pramod Kumar, editor of this effort to support and sustain Maithili, has five bīhani stories in the collection. A child quite reasonably declares his mother backward because she does not know how to make biryani; and in the post-Corona period, too, someone unfamiliar with Google, Classroom, PPT and all manner of similar things is pronounced backward. Munni Kamat's feminism is evident in "Girls Hostel," with its "attempt once again to free

the body"; the bīhani story is thus capable of serving as an instrument of feminist writing. Amaresh Kumar Labh's "Kariki" reinforces the attitude expressed in the words "Neither did she study, nor did she get any big job!"—a new ointment, as it were, for turning dark skin fair, after which finding a groom would supposedly present no difficulty. Vidya Chandra Jha "Bambam" is himself afflicted by a demon of love in "Maf Kar Saki Ta"; in "Prabha" he draws an uncle into its grip, while Satyendra Karna calls that same demon "Dimag Phoojab": the final truth. Bindeshwar Thakur remains an old-fashioned man: he likes neither the son's misbehaviour in "Sokaj" nor the daughter-in-law's in "Bahasal Kaniya." Abha Jha's "Laj" strikes at men's definition of morality. Shiv Kumar, too, in "Formality," identifies the conflicts arising within families in the atmosphere of the new economy. Priyamvada's "Swabhiman" opposes the "price of a daughter's marriage." In "Goli," Mahakant Prasad compares the Prime Minister's "Mann Ki Baat" to a goli—a pill or bullet—although he does not actually use the word "Prime Minister." Prabhas Akinchan writes "Kaparachhilla" about the upanayana rite, which people remember only just before marriage. Ashish Anchinhar's "Sthiti" concerns a woman's situation before and after marriage; Poonam Jha, in "Upadesh," makes clear the difference between people's preaching and their conduct. Shubhra Santosh's "Mol Bhav" exposes a grotesque aspect of men and, at the same time, the strength within women. Jawahar Lal Kashyap enters the psychology of both owner and dog in "Kukkur"; in "Hero," he writes about names and the idea familiar from Shakespeare that a rose would retain its fragrance even if it bore another name. Through "Code Word," Subhash Kumar Kamat shows that news of a daughter's birth brings happiness, yet fear of events in society can make people unwilling to bring a daughter into the world. Munna is delighted, but Sudha becomes anxious after watching television news. Neeraj Karna attacks deviousness through "Father's Day." Kumari Aarti's "Jeevansangi," however, keeps alive the hope that a woman and a man may live in harmony as wife and husband. Kalpana Jha–1 (Bokaro) comments on the pollution of the Ganga in "Santap," while "Sappat" looks closely at a daughter's anger as she watches her son and husband eat. Kalpana Jha–2 (Patna), in "Facebookiya Jingi," addresses the problems of old age while also commenting on Facebook posts: she thus shows that, despite its small dimensions, a bīhani story may hold two plots at once. Sabita Jha "Soni" reveals a feminist concern in "Naut": does hunger strike men before anyone else? Vinita Thakur's "Samay Ker Maral" seeks to explain the reversals of time through hunger. Mrinal Ashutosh's "Newton Ke Third Law" portrays the condition of a woman in a live-in relationship, but brings the story to a close not through helplessness but through action and reaction—"Newton's Third Law." He does not himself use the words "action and reaction," because Mithila has now achieved enough scientific literacy for people to

understand these words from the mere mention of "Newton's Third Law." In "Nam Uchch Kan Bucch," Amar Thakur elucidates the meaning of the saying "What is the use of growing tall, like a date-palm tree?" Through "Niputra," Manisha Jha shows how a single person can display two different personalities when faced with suffering of their own and that of others. In "Aas," Ruby Jha considers a mother's and child's obstinacy under two different circumstances; in "Tugar," she examines the experience of comparable suffering among human beings and animals. Om Prakash Jha's "Purna Dalan" reverses the familiar idea "a new house rises, an old house falls": it is not a story about an old courtyard building collapsing, but about a place of shelter for a pair of birds. This is a fitting ending for a bīhani story. His "Special Permit," included in Videha Maithili Bīhani Katha (Videha: Sadeha 5), is likewise an inversion reminiscent of Kabir's उलटबाँसी (ulṭabāsī). It is in this manner that a bīhani story ought to end, as I wrote in "The Critical Theory of the Bīhani Story" (Videha: Sadeha 5). Himadri Mishra "Him" describes exchanges of sharp words between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law in "Adhikar." In "Peer Na Jane Koy," Ira Mallick uses the example of grinding grain at the mill all night in order to forget grief, demonstrating the bīhani story's capacity for psychological analysis: the night is difficult to pass; the day passes somehow. Kanchan Kanth ends "Barabari" on a humorous note. Rajesh Verma "Bhavaditya" suggests something further through a person becoming the ghost of his present self, followed by a dispute between the two; after all, people change their opinions when their roles change. Misida clarifies the same point in five lines in "Sapna," through three ideas —literature, creative writing, and politics. Jayanti Kumari's "Khounjhi" is a bold bīhani story. Beginning with crockery being banged about in the kitchen in anger, it opens with the feminist stance of Soni, a domestic helper; it ends by showing that the mistress of the house, Rekha, is part of that same discourse. The author possesses the ability to achieve such a conclusion—what may be called an apex ending. Kalpana Kumari's "Jhamaral Mon" focuses on divisions of family property and inheritance. Santwana Mishra, even in "Bhagwati Janam Leli," seems to be saying that women themselves are responsible for women's troubles—or that women, too, bear responsibility. Nandini Jha, however, reverses this in "Bhadba" and demonstrates that a mother-in-law can be progressive. Bhuvaneshwar Chaurasia "Bhunesh" produces humour through verbal wrangling in "Sahamat"; Amar Kant Lal does likewise in "MRP." Deepa Mishra knows that women are often called the more "clever" ones, but says, "It must be men who are clever," and thereby gets men to do a great deal of work. https://videha123.files.wordpress.com/2010/10/videha_01_10_2010.pdf — Videha Maithili Bīhani Katha.

3

In the introduction to Sajhiyā Ropani (the shared anthology of bīhani stories), its editor, Dr Pramod Kumar, writes of the qualities of the bīhani story: "It contains all the qualities of a long story, such as dialogue, atmosphere, craft, seriousness of subject matter, purpose, and relevance."

His strict measure for a bīhani story is one hundred words, which can be read in two minutes; this naturally brings to mind the advertisement for two-minute noodles. His editorial strength lies in assembling every kind of bīhani story in this collection: some humorous and some serious, some concerned with women's questions, and others with Corona and Facebook. He has thus shown that even a humorous miniature, when contextually meaningful, may be recognised and collected as a bīhani story (see "The Critical Theory of the Bīhani Story," Videha: Sadeha 5). The need to write a commentary on the Aṣṭādhyāyī many times larger than the original was felt roughly five hundred years after its composition, and such a commentary was indeed written. In the same way, if the bīhani stories collected here were reviewed, not merely as part of this anthology but also independently, those reviews would occupy several times more space than the stories themselves. This is a distinguishing quality of the bīhani stories gathered in this collection, and for that reason the compiler-editor deserves our thanks.

26. Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’s’ “Māṭik Bāsan” and a Critical Commentary

Abstract

A series of invited writings by authors and critical responses by invited reviewers: Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’s’ children’s story “Māṭik Bāsan” and Gajendra Thakur’s commentary on it. “Māṭik Bāsan” was published electronically in Videha and collected in Videha: Sadeha 32 (pp. 2–5); it is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm. Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’, village and post office: Haripur Dih Tol, Madhubani. Kedar Prasad, a skilled potter of the village.

Keywords: Jagadanand · clay · vessels · critical · commentary · any · Kedar

Abstract

A series of invited writings by authors and critical responses by invited reviewers: Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’s’ children’s story “Māṭik Bāsan” and Gajendra Thakur’s commentary on it. “Māṭik Bāsan” was published electronically in Videha and collected in Videha: Sadeha 32 (pp. 2–5); it is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm. Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’, village and post office: Haripur Dih Tol, Madhubani. Kedar Prasad was a skilled potter of the village. He made his living by producing clay vessels such as ghail (water-pots), lids and matkuris. For him, making earthenware was not merely a livelihood but also a beautiful craft.

A Series of Invited Literary Works and Invited Critical Reviews: Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’s’ Children’s Story “Māṭik Bāsan,” with a Commentary by Gajendra Thakur

“Māṭik Bāsan” was published electronically in Videha and collected in Videha: Sadeha 32 (pp. 2–5); the issue is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm.

First, let us read the story again:

Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’, village and post office: Haripur Dih Tol, Madhubani

Māṭik Bāsan (Clay Vessels)

Kedar Prasad was a skilled potter in his village. He supported himself by making clay vessels—ghail water-pots, lids, matkuris and the like. Making earthenware was not merely his means of livelihood; to him it was a beautiful craft. While working, he became so wholly absorbed that he seemed like a devotee who, in meditation upon his chosen deity, forgets all awareness of body and mind. Through his own sustained practice, he gradually began making handsome, attractive clay elephants for Chhath

Maiya as well. His earthenware and his Chhath elephants won much admiration.

Gradually the village environment began to change. Steel and other metals started to take the place of clay vessels. Kedar Prasad's income began to fall, but his faithfulness and dedication to his work meant that he could not bring himself to give up pottery.

His handsome, well-mannered son Bibhu had been trained in the hereditary craft since childhood. There was no hesitation in saying that he was even better at it than his father. Kedar Prasad knew this very well and was inwardly both pleased by his gifted son and worried about him. His worry arose because he knew the present state of the potter's trade and could foresee its future; yet, seeing Bibhu's skill with his hands, he did not consider it right to keep him away from the craft. Alongside his schooling, Bibhu continued to acquire all his father's skills. Going beyond the clay elephants his father made for Chhath, he began using his craftsmanship to fashion sculptures. People throughout the village started talking about his work. Where a Chhath elephant made by his father fetched eleven rupees, Bibhu's small dolls and figures began fetching a hundred or a hundred and twenty-five rupees apiece. Under his father's supervision, Bibhu advanced in sculpture day after day. Soon there was demand for his images of Mother Saraswati and the deities of Krishna Janmashtami and Vishwakarma Puja in twenty surrounding villages. Yet his father still pointed out some defect or other in each sculpture and encouraged him to make the next one better. Bibhu treated his father's words like sacred instruction and applied himself to making still finer images.

After the tenth standard, Bibhu left school and devoted himself entirely to sculpture. By the age of eighteen he had become fully discerning and had learnt to distinguish what was good from what was bad. His statues were now admired not only in his village or district but across the state. A single statue of his might fetch two or three thousand rupees. Yet his father continued to find some shortcoming in each sculpture and to instruct him to produce a more beautiful one. Earlier, Bibhu had treated those words as sacred and immediately set about correcting the deficiency. Now, however, his father's comments began to wound him somewhere within. He lacked the courage to object, so he suppressed his feelings and followed the instructions he was given.

Work continued somehow, and news of Bibhu's sculptures now began to travel beyond the state's borders. He received a letter from the Home Department of the state government, informing him that arrangements had been made to exhibit his sculpture at an all-India sculpture exhibition. The state government would bear all the expenses; the winner would receive the honour of being named the country's finest sculptor, together

with a cash prize of one lakh rupees. The letter made Bibhu immensely happy. He ran straight to his father to tell him. Kedar Prasad, too, was delighted: the labour of his entire life was beginning to bear fruit. Bibhu stayed awake night after night, working beside his father, guide and teacher.

He made one fine sculpture after another, but Kedar Prasad unfailingly found a fault in each. Instead of setting about correcting the flaws his father identified, Bibhu now began to harbour negative feelings. He started answering back and questioning his father's criticisms. Tomorrow was the last day for sending a sculpture to the competition, and today Bibhu was giving the finishing touches to the one he considered the best of all he had made. As Kedar Prasad examined it minutely, Bibhu's mind was in turmoil: 'Yes, he will certainly point out some mistake or other even now.'

At length Kedar Prasad broke his silence: "Beautiful! The finest of all the sculptures you have made so far." After a brief pause, he added: "But..."

But what? Bibhu's mind flared up. "He is bound to find some fault," he thought.

Kedar Prasad went on: "If this part had been like this, it would have been even better; and if this colour had been such-and-such, it would have been magnificent."

From childhood Bibhu had treated this man's words as a sacred command and had poured his heart and soul into carrying them out. Today, however, he could not bear what his father said. He burst out angrily: "Enough! Finding faults is all you know how to do. No one will buy even one of the clay lids and vessels you make for a single rupee, yet however fine a sculpture I produce, you will always discover something wrong with it."

At Bibhu's words, Kedar Prasad's calm expression changed and he sank into thought. With a deep sigh he patted Bibhu on the back and said, "Enough, son, enough! The moment a person begins to feel that he has attained perfection, his growth comes to a halt. The belief that one is perfect paralyses the mind's capacity to move forward."

For a few moments there was silence. Both remained still. Tears streamed from Bibhu's eyes. What had he done today? He realised his mistake. Kedar Prasad continued: "It was my dream that my son would become the finest sculptor not merely in the state or the country, but in the whole world... But no. Never mind. Who knew me? No one. The whole state knows my son as a good sculptor. That is a very great thing for me. But my dream—now it will never come true." With these words he left the room.

An Examination of the Story

After the story's first paragraph comes the statement, "Steel and other metals began taking the place of clay vessels." As soon as I read this, I recalled Jigri, the English translation of a Telugu novel (Jigri by the Telugu novelist Pedinti Ashok Kumar, translated into English as Friends Forever by P. Jayalakshmi). It tells of a family that earns its living by making a bear dance, and of the bond between the bear and the human beings. When the government bans the practice, all that remains of this marginal culture is its memory, for the family would have to cross numerous political and cultural boundaries in order to be rehabilitated.

Positive Aspects of the Story

In this story, however, the author gives this process of change a promising turn. The son begins making sculptures instead of the clay lids and vessels made by his father. There is another difference: the government has placed no prohibition on the making of earthenware. Indeed, you may recall the fashion for selling and drinking tea in clay cups on trains, a practice the government helped to promote. Yet the memory of this marginal culture is present in me, surely in you, and in the storyteller too. The writer, however, carries the story forward by linking it to the folktale tradition, in which moral instruction is a purpose of children's literature. One is reminded of Shivshankar Srinivas's "Pandit O Hunak Putra" ("The Pandit and His Son"), a children's story based on a Mithila folktale, electronically published in Videha and included in Videha: Sadeha 4 (pp. 138–141); it is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm. Srinivas's story is explicitly based on a folktale, whereas only the final portion of "Māṭik Bāsan" is inspired by one. The purpose of "Māṭik Bāsan" does not, in the end, become the modernisation of a marginal culture: it comes to be the same purpose as that of Srinivas's story. Srinivas arrived there through the rewriting of a folktale; Jagadanand, while attempting to depict the modernisation of a marginal culture, abandons his original narrative plot and pursues that same subject instead.

Negative Aspects of the Story

I have previously discussed Jagadanand's children's novel, Chonaha.

A long story for children—or, one might call it a novel—by Jagadanand Jha "Manu", entitled Chonaha, was published in Videha. The work was later collected in Videha: Sadeha 9 (Videha Children's Festival, pp. 109–126) and is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm. It is the first work in Maithili based on child psychology. This novel ought to be included in a training course on how to write children's literature in Maithili. It shows how a modern

novel develops, step by step—and a children's novel at that. I urge you simply to read it.

But in "Māṭik Bāsan", Jagadanand disappointed me. I had expected from him something like Pedinti Ashok Kumar's Jigri; what I found instead was something as ordinary as Shivshankar Srinivas's "Pandit O Hunak Putra" ("The Pandit and His Son").

It is true that "Māṭik Bāsan" is a children's bīhani story. Yet for a writer who has the plot—

"Steel and other metals began taking the place of clay vessels"—
to end the story with—

"But my dream—now it will never come true." Saying this, he left the room.
is not acceptable to me. Thus a remarkable plot has been reduced to a good but mediocre story.

Analysis

This story needs to be developed further. That might be done by increasing its length, but its subject could equally be expanded within the same word limit. The author has strayed from his objective: he has failed to develop the statement "Steel and other metals began taking the place of clay vessels." I had not expected this from the author of Chonaha. Jagadanand will have to rewrite the story; in that process it may remain a bīhani story, or become a short story, a longer story, or even a novel.

27. Krishna Kumar Kashyap and Shashibala: An Introduction to Their Creative Work

Abstract

Krishna Kumar Kashyap was born on 15 September 1949. His father was the late Indranarayan Lal "Sanwaliya," a poet and novelist. In January 1965 he established a "Night School" for children. In 1981 he introduced an "art-based approach to life and teaching" and, to put it into practice, founded the Bharati Vikas Sanstha with the assistance of Shiva Kashyap and Shashibala.

Keywords: Krishna Kumar Kashyap · Shashibala · creative work · introduction · Mithila

Krishna Kumar Kashyap and Shashibala: An Introduction

Krishna Kumar Kashyap was born on 15 September 1949 and died on 12 August 2020. His father was the late Indranarayan Lal "Sanwaliya," a poet and novelist. In January 1965 he opened a "Night School" for children. In 1981 he introduced an "art-based approach to life and teaching" and, with the support of Shiva Kashyap and Shashibala, established the Bharati Vikas Sanstha to implement it. His works include Maithili translations of Meghadūta and Gīta-Govinda in collaboration with Shashibala; Māchh-Bhāt; Mithila Chitra Praveśikā, Parts I–II; Mithila Chitra-Kor, Part III; Mithila Aripan, Part IV; Godnā Chitra-Śailī, Part V; and Mithila Lokchitra.

Shashibala's father is Shri Ugra Narayan Lal and her husband is Shri Umesh Kumar Kanth of Bisahath. Her works include collaborative Maithili translations of Meghadūta and Gīta-Govinda with Krishna Kumar Kashyap; Māchh-Bhāt; Mithila Chitra Praveśikā, Parts I–II; Mithila Chitra-Kor, Part III; Mithila Aripan, Part IV; Godnā Chitra-Śailī, Part V; and Mithila Lokchitra.

In my second interview with Krishna Kumar Kashyap, he expressed his views on various dimensions of art. He was concerned about the practice of calling Mithila painting "Madhubani painting." The division between the

Jitwarpur school and Mithila artists working elsewhere also emerged in the conversation.

"When visitors come from outside, they ask which district our village belongs to. Once they learn that we are from Darbhanga, not Madhubani district, they say, 'YOU ARE NOT FROM THE ORIGINAL PLACE.' In other words, they assume that our painting is not genuine Madhubani painting, and this suits the Jitwarpur school."

Naren Karunakaran writes in his article "Mithila's Women Paint Their Way Out of Poverty": "In Barheta village of Bihar, Bharati Vikas Manch is teaching impoverished women the Mithila method of painting, enabling many of them to find a means of escaping poverty."

Karunakaran also writes that Shashibala, Kashyap's first pupil and now a teacher there, told him that "the elephant-themed paintings produced by the hands of a poor Musahar community are exceptionally beautiful." Shashibala further explained that the hands of the women who worked as labourers tended to be somewhat rough; where some could not learn the delicate handling of the brush, they were assigned other crafts, such as basket-making and tablecloth-making, instead of painting. Many, however, gradually learnt to use the brush.

Alongside the five colours associated with earth, water, fire, sky and air—kṣiti, jala, pāvaka, gagana and samīra—the entry of Dalit and Adivasi themes, lines and incised designs into Mithila painting has brought the godnā, or tattoo-derived, style into the art.

Krishna Kumar Kashyap admitted a girl from the Dom community to his school. The other pupils supported her, but some villagers opposed her admission. There were also Muslim girls at his school, and they never hesitated to paint Hindu themes.

Gajendra Thakur

Shweta Jha Chaudhary: An Introduction

Shweta Jha Chaudhary, of Sarisab-Pahi village, holds a degree in Fine Arts and Home Science and has completed a certificate course in Mithila painting. Her art exhibitions include the cultural programme at XLRI, Jamshedpur; the Gram-Shree Fair, Jamshedpur; and exhibitions and workshops at Kala Mandir, Jamshedpur.

Her art-related activities include serving as a judge at an art competition at NIT Jamshedpur; teaching Mithila painting at Basera, Jamshedpur, from 2002 to 2007; and producing wall paintings for the Women's College library and Hotel Boulevard. Her notable sponsors include Corporate Communications, TISCO; TSRDS, TISCO; AIADA; the State Bank of India, Jamshedpur; and various individuals, hotels, organisations and private art collectors. Her interests include Mithila painting, fine arts, music and cooking.

I

This painting depicts a Mithila village at harvest time. Men bring the crop home from the fields, while the women process it into rice. During this season, women step outside their everyday routines, gather together and exchange conversation and laughter.

2

Whenever love is mentioned, the first image that comes to mind is Radha and Krishna. This painting is an attempt to depict that love.

3

There is no limit to the pleasure of swinging in the month of Sāvan, breathing the fragrance of earth moistened by fine rain.

4

The Palanquin Bearers

The young bride's conflicting feelings on her journey to her husband's home: sorrow at leaving her natal family, and excitement at entering a

new life. Unaware of this inner turmoil, the palanquin bearers cheerfully carry her to her in-laws' home.

5

Kariyā-Jhummari

Kariyā-Jhummari is a popular game among the girls of Mithila. Both the young and the older girls enjoy playing it.

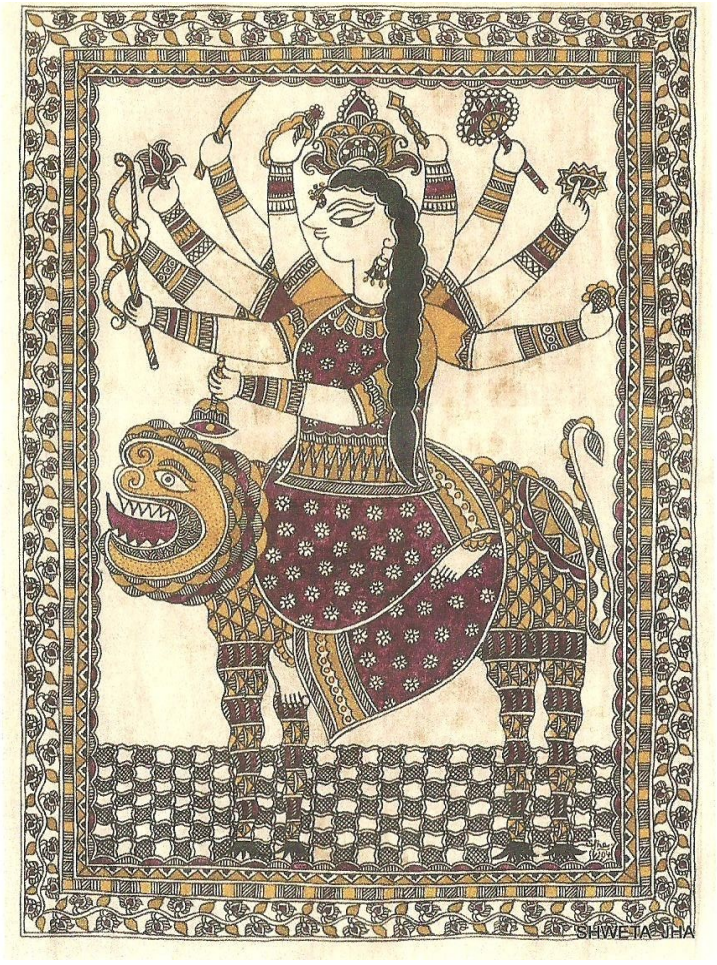
6

The Holy Man

An attempt to portray a sādhu-bābā in a modern manner within Mithila painting.

7

Durgā Pūjā



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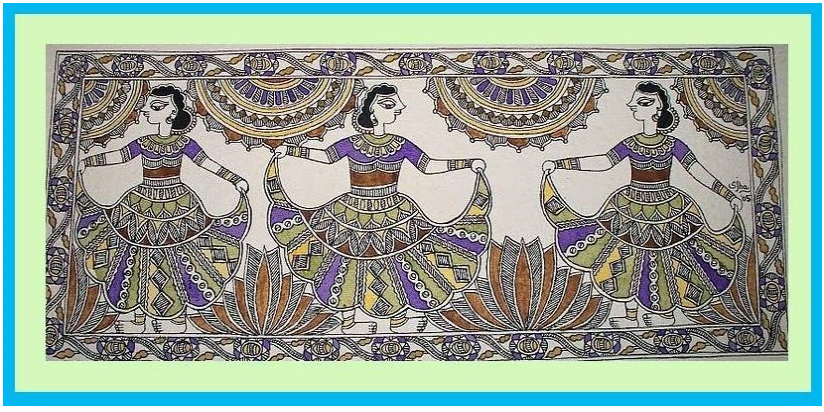
Mother Kālī

9

The Water Carrier

10

11



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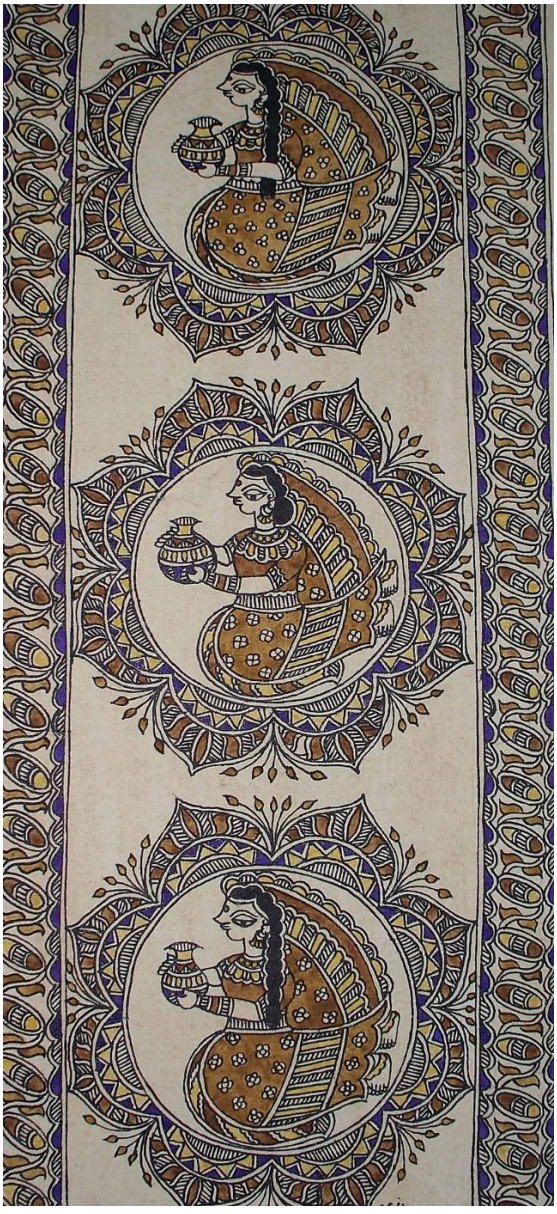
On the painting: the sun is a symbol of hope and of the fulfilment of resolve; it represents light after darkness. It is the root of life on earth and the blessing of divinity. It is therefore revered in cultures throughout the world, particularly in Maithil culture during Chhath and Makar Sankranti. This painting seeks to depict these meanings.

13



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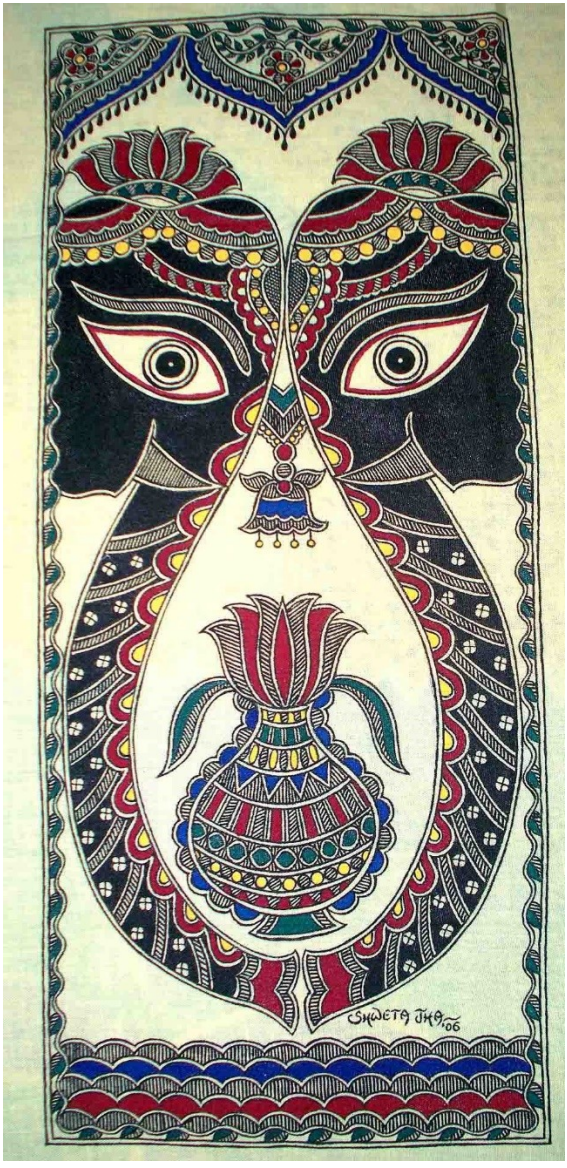

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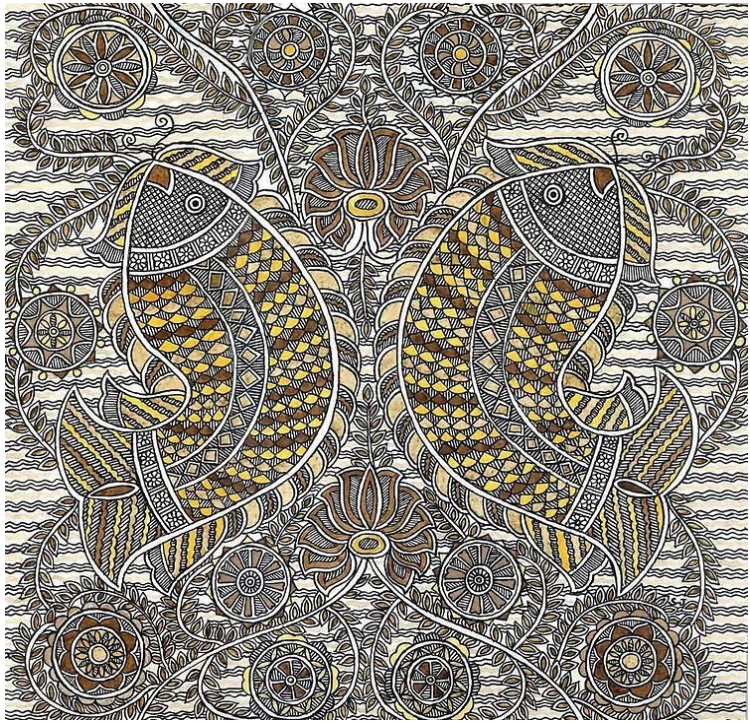

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(Videha: Sadeha 35)

28. Pandit Bal Govind "Arya"

Abstract

Introduction to Pandit Bal Govind "Arya's" Commentary on the Section on Letters. At a Mailorang seminar in Delhi, the late Mohan Bharadwaj had asked a grammarian of the mainstream: "Why is there no grammar in Maithili? Are we not capable of having a grammar of our own in Maithili?"

Keywords: Bal Govind Arya · Maithili grammar · study of letters · indigenous grammar · linguistics · grammatical tradition

Introduction to Pandit Bal Govind "Arya's" Commentary on the Section on Letters

At a Mailorang seminar in Delhi, the late Mohan Bharadwaj addressed a grammarian of the mainstream: "Why is there no grammar in Maithili? Are we not capable of having a grammar of our own in Maithili?"

Yet the mainstream seems to consider its duty discharged merely by patching together Hindi and Sanskrit grammars and making adjustments of the sort that say: in Hindi, ham ("we") is plural, whereas in Maithili it can be singular. Govindacharya of the parallel tradition, however, constructed a genuine grammar in opposition to such a makeshift, patchwork grammar. This became possible, as in Pāṇini's case, through his habit of extensive travel.

Consider how both nīra, used in southern India, and jala, used in northern India, denote water in Sanskrit. If, when teaching conversational Sanskrit, you taught a southern Indian "ahaṃ nīraṃ pibāmi" and a northern Indian "ahaṃ jalaṃ pibāmi," would you not be regarded as a good teacher?

Govindacharya—Pandit Bal Govind "Arya," the well-known Govind Yadav—has produced the commentary and introduction to the Varṇa-Prakaraṇa (Maithili grammar), which should also prove useful to schoolteachers.

29. Structural Instability and the Play of Meaning: A Critique of Ramesh's Kathā-Samay

Abstract

Structural Instability and the Play of Meaning: A Critique of Ramesh's Maithili Short-Story Collection Kathā-Samay. Critical discussion of Maithili literature has traditionally oscillated between sentimental regionalism and realism. In the contemporary moment, however, the text must also be understood as a field of linguistic and ideological contradictions. Ramesh's Kathā-Samay, bringing together the collections Samānāntar (1997) and Samāṅ (1991), presents a complex linguistic map of a Maithil society fractured between tradition and modernity.

Keywords: structural · instability · play of meaning · Ramesh · criticism · analysis

Abstract

Structural Instability and the Play of Meaning: A Critique of Ramesh's Maithili Short-Story Collection Kathā-Samay. Critical discussion of Maithili literature has traditionally oscillated between sentimental regionalism and realism. In the contemporary moment, however, the text must also be understood as a field of linguistic and ideological contradictions. Ramesh's Kathā-Samay, bringing together the collections Samānāntar (1997) and Samāṅ (1991), presents a complex linguistic map of a Maithil society fractured between tradition and modernity. To deconstruct these stories is not merely to separate the elements of their plots; it is to identify the aporia, or logical impasse, at which a text begins to unsettle its own message.

Structural Instability and the Play of Meaning: A Critique of Ramesh's Maithili Story Collection Kathā-Samay

Critical discussion of Maithili literature has traditionally oscillated between sentimental regionalism and realism. In the contemporary moment, however, the text must also be understood as a field of linguistic and ideological contradictions. Ramesh's Kathā-Samay, which incorporates the collections Samānāntar (1997) and Samāṅ (1991), presents a complex linguistic map of a Maithil society fractured between tradition and modernity. To deconstruct these stories is not merely to separate the elements of their plots; it is to identify the aporia, or logical impasse, at which a text begins to unsettle its own message. A close analysis of the stories in Kathā-Samay shows how they disrupt binary hierarchies and expose a condition of undecidability.

The Theoretical Perspective of Deconstruction and Maithili Prose

Deconstruction treats language as a system of différance. According to Derrida, meaning never remains fixed: it is continually displaced or deferred from one word to another. This is particularly important for

Maithili literature because Maithili itself exists in a state of continuing dialogue and tension with Sanskrit, Hindi and English. The critic's aim is to locate the text's logocentrism—the assumption that there is a single ultimate truth—and then to unsettle it.

Ramesh's stories are immersed in the socio-economic realities of northern Bihar and south-eastern Nepal, yet they also play with such oppositions as urban/rural, state/individual and knowledge/taboo. Deconstructive reading reveals that these stories do not merely "reflect" reality. They participate in a play of signifiers in which the supposed "protector"—the state, the parent or the teacher—often turns out to be a "devourer" or a "terrorist."

Deconstructing "Palāṣṭī Ke Khelonā" (Plastic Toys)

"Palāṣṭī Ke Khelonā" is an important story in the collection. It portrays the conflict between a father's idealistic humanism and the consumerist culture disseminated by television and cinema. The father regards a certain high culture as superior: Pandit Ravi Shankar's sitar is placed above Bombay films.

The Breakdown of the Art/Violence Opposition

This hierarchy collapses when the son, Pappu, rejects the "sitar," the symbol of humanism, and chooses a "pistol." The father argues that the sitar, as art, is superior to violence. For the child, however, the pistol signifies not "violence" but "smartness" and "agility," whereas the sitar seems to represent rigidity and inertia. Thus the story also dissolves the opposition between "innocence in childhood" and "uncomprehending aggression."

The State as Protector and Devourer

One of the story's central aporias emerges when the father tells his wife that there is no difference between "government terrorists" (the police) and "private terrorists" (criminals). This statement deconstructs the logocentric claim that the state is a protector. If the police and the criminal perform functionally identical roles, the very foundation of the social order becomes unstable.

Presence and Absence in "Kankhī"

In "Kankhī" (The Side-Glance), Ramesh depicts the failure of the system through Bihar's electricity crisis from 1991 to 2019.

Fleeting Hope and the Trace of Time

Deconstruction: Concepts and Their Application to Maithili Prose

Concept	Deconstructionist definition	Application to Maithili prose
Binary opposition	A pair such as presence/absence	Tension between village tradition and the ruthlessness of the city
Aporia	Logical impasse or internal contradiction	When the ritual of marriage turns into the "sacrifice" of land
Trace	The lingering effect of an earlier meaning within a word	A form such as "pilsim", behind which lies the failure of public administration
Undecidability	The condition of being unable to reach a final meaning	An ending in which neither victory nor defeat is conclusive

The opposition between light (electricity) and darkness (load-shedding) is central to the story. Modern life takes electricity as "presence," yet in Jha Babu's life "absence" is continually present. The same flicker of electricity —bhuk-bhuk—persists in 1991 and in 2019: time has passed, but the trace of failure remains. When Jha Babu receives a bill of seven hundred rupees despite living in darkness, that "bill," as signifier, no longer has a corresponding actual meaning, or signified.

"Naramedha": The Economics of Sacrifice

"Naramedha" exposes the horrifying character of dowry, as ancestral land is sold to pay for Sanju's wedding.

The Land/Capital Opposition

Land is "Annapūrṇā," the giver of food, while capital is a "demon." The opposition between the grandmother's supposed "madness" and the parents' supposed "wisdom" is deconstructed. The grandmother understands that selling the land amounts to suicide; the parents, however, silence her with an injection in order to preserve the "sanctity" of the marriage. When she dies at the time of the sale, the marriage/mourning binary collapses. The "success" of the wedding depends upon the "presence" of death.

"Had Dinkar Babu Been Under a Delusion?": The Fragmentation of the Family

In this story, Ramesh portrays television as a medium that fractures the family instead of bringing it together. Dinkar Babu values news, or truth, while his children are absorbed in "disco music" and "scenes of rape." In the final scene he watches his children imitate the violence shown on television: it is the deconstruction of "innocence."

"The Mirror Trade in Nāgades": Mirrors and Reality

This story is an allegory in which the inhabitants of the village of Nāgadah legitimise their corruption by attaching it to religious belief.

The mirror becomes a deconstructive site where the "self" is transformed into an "other." The trader's mirror deconstructs the village myth: when people look into it, they see not a goddess but a snake. This is presented as confirming Derrida's proposition that there is no "ultimate truth" outside language: everything is only a reflection.

The Female Body and "Dudhuā"

"Dudhuā" views the female body through the opposition between motherhood and beauty. Kamini's husband treats her body solely as an object of sexual desire and arranges for injections to dry up her breast milk. From a deconstructive perspective, this is an attempt to erase the "sign" of motherhood. When Kamini develops breast cancer, however, that "absence" turns into "presence" in the form of illness.

"Octopus": An Ecological Aporia

In "Octopus," Neha sees urban pollution as a monster. Her education in botany enables her to name the devastation but not to stop it. This is an aporia of knowledge: the more she knows about nature, the more acutely she recognises its destruction. Industry, supposedly a symbol of progress, is killing the very city it has developed. The development/destruction hierarchy is thus deconstructed.

"Praveś-Niṣedh" (Entry Prohibited): Silence and Taboo

"Praveś-Niṣedh" deconstructs society's tendency to maintain "silence" about sex education. Kishore wants to read the chapter on the reproductive system in his science textbook, but his teachers and guardians dismiss it as "dirty." The story shows that silence does not protect; it can kill. Kishore's sister-in-law dies in childbirth because of ignorance. His declaration, "Your M.A. degree is worthless," reverses the conventional opposition between education and ignorance.

"Dhrupad-Dhamār": Music and Deprivation

This story uses the vocabulary of classical music to expose inflation and the failure of the state. Pandit Tuntun Misar is a retired teacher dependent upon his "pilsim" (pension). The governor's "promise" printed on the currency note has become a hollow signifier, for inflation has emptied that promise of value. When the minister speaks of "computerisation" and Tuntun Misar of "kerosene," the modern/primitive binary collapses.

Deconstructing Other Stories in Samāṅ

"Ek Ser Chāur" (A Seer of Rice): The opposition between dignity and survival. A mother sells her "flower-patterned plate," a token of dignity, in exchange for rice. The story thus deconstructs human values.

"Sahānubhūti" (Sympathy): The opposition between protector and devourer. The village headman takes a woman to his orchard under the appearance of sympathy, but his compassion is in fact a signifier masking exploitation.

"Luṭṭīs-Kes": Building an embankment along the Kamala River breaks down the opposition between safety and danger. The embankment is built not to provide safety but to facilitate plunder.

Binary Oppositions and Their Deconstructive Reversal

Binary pair	Privileged term	Subordinate term	Deconstructive reversal
Beauty / biology	A body like that of a "heroine"	Milk / maternity	Suppression contributes to an illness such as cancer
Husband / child	Husband's desire	Mother's duty	Both roles consume the woman's body
Health / image	External appearance	Biological function	In the pursuit of an "image", health is destroyed

"Akṣa Ā Vṛttacakra" (Axis and Circle): The conflict between love and economics. On a wedding anniversary, the centre—the axis—is not love but the accounting of debts and bills.

Linguistic Instability

The Hindi and English words in Ramesh's Maithili prose are not merely signs of modernity. They are traces of a culture that is displacing Maithili itself.

"Pilsim" (Pension): This distortion of the word becomes a symbol of institutional corruption.

"Mummy/Papa" as against "Mā/Bābūjī": The change in forms of address deconstructs traditional patriarchal authority.

"Bhuā" (Caterpillar): This is not merely an insect; it becomes a trace of the male erotic gaze.

Conclusion: Mithila's Undecided Future

The collection Kathā-Samay ends not with resolution but with a deep sense of undecidability. Ramesh does not offer a "moral of the story" in the traditional sense. Instead, he leaves his characters at an intersection of aporias. Neha is still in the haze; Dinkar Babu is still watching the children wrestle; Sanju is still wearing her golden insect-shaped fetters.

From a deconstructive perspective, this absence of resolution is the text's greatest strength. It refuses to offer a "transcendental signified," any final and easy answer to Mithila's problems. Instead, it invites readers to enter into the play of meaning, to perceive the trace of the village within the town and the trace of the serpent within the official.

Ramesh's writing demonstrates that the "Maithili path" is a complex, unstable and profoundly reflective language. By deconstructing the binaries of state, family and body, Kathā-Samay exposes the fissures in modern Maithil identity. For the literary critic the collection is not merely a book of stories, but a "watch-platform" that makes visible the "holes" in society's construction—those places where truth and falsehood, protector and predator, life and death remain inextricably intertwined. Kathā-Samay thus stands as decisive evidence that Maithili literature has moved beyond the "metaphysics of presence" and entered the demanding, multidimensional world of poststructuralist reality.

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30. Umesh Paswan's Mujrim: A Critical Reading of the Short-Story Collection

Abstract

Through the educated young woman Sunanda and her father, Raman Master, the story "Sunanda" exposes society's narrow-mindedness. Out of compassion, Sunanda brings home a newborn infant abandoned beside the road, but the village brands her a woman of loose character. It is later revealed that the baby was born to the unmarried daughter of a prominent family in the village.

Keywords: Umesh Paswan · Mujrim · story collection · critical reading

Abstract

Through the educated young woman Sunanda and her father, Raman Master, the story "Sunanda" exposes society's narrow-mindedness. Out of compassion, Sunanda brings home a newborn infant abandoned beside the road, but the village brands her a woman of loose character. Her father, too, succumbs to public pressure.

Umesh Paswan's Mujrim

Umesh Paswan's Mujrim contains a collection of sixteen stories.

I

"Sunanda" exposes the narrowness of social attitudes through an educated young woman, Sunanda, and her father, Raman Master. Moved by compassion, Sunanda brings home a newborn baby abandoned beside the road. The villagers, however, accuse her of immorality; even her father yields to social pressure. Eventually it is disclosed that the child was born to the unmarried daughter of one of the village's prominent families. Once the truth emerges, every allegation is shown to be false. The story effectively brings out the readiness with which women are blamed, the pressures of caste prestige, malicious gossip and the real meaning of humanity. Finally, moral courage and a willingness to forgive point society towards a better path.

"Solakanmā Pokhair" (The Pond of the Solakanma Hamlet) reveals the bitter irony of a severe water crisis compounded by caste discrimination. Although the pond in the Solakanma settlement contains water, members of the upper castes avoid using it; anyone who does so faces social ostracism. Untouchability and ideas of high and low status outweigh the basic human need for water. Then a fire breaks out and the entire village is saved by water drawn from that very pond. What was denounced as impure becomes life-giving in a crisis. The story makes clear that natural resources belong equally to everyone and that emergencies expose the artificial nature of social divisions.

"Karmak Phal" (The Fruits of One's Deeds) recounts Ranjit's downfall. The educated son of a respectable household falls under the influence of bad companions and becomes addicted to alcohol. The first time he drinks, supposedly as a joke, the police catch him and he is sent to prison, where association with criminals redirects his life. He later enters the liquor trade, is arrested, becomes a fugitive and, disguised as a holy man, attempts to cheat people. When his identity is revealed, the public hands him over to the police. Ultimately the seizure and attachment of his family's property leave the household ruined. The story insists that bad company and immoral acts inevitably have destructive consequences.

"Girahat Ghar Par Giddh" (Vultures over the Landlord's House) is set against caste discrimination and social confrontation in Daulatpur village. Dalit youths are made to rise from a row of diners at a śrāddha feast. Subsequently a young man is beaten and punished for entering a temple. The humiliated Dalit community resolves to stop removing dead livestock from upper-caste households and to suspend its traditional services. Soon animals begin dying of disease, and vultures circle the village, leaving the landlords themselves in difficulty. Eventually the village council intervenes and the issue of equal rights is raised. The story foregrounds dignity, labour and equality.

"Tetar Das" follows the life of a boy named Tetra. His mother dies giving birth to him, so villagers regard him as an ill omen and call him "Lūṭnā." His father brings him up lovingly, and he proves exceptionally able at school. Through the study of Sanskrit he becomes a scholar, acquires renown as a saint and is known as Tetar Das. Thousands are influenced by his discourses. But when his name is proposed for the position of mahant at the Govindpur monastery, caste-based objections arise. Deeply wounded, he abandons everything and returns to his village. The story poignantly exposes caste prejudice and society's disregard for talent.

"Kodāri Chhāp" (The Spade Symbol) exposes the interplay of power and greed in a village-council election. To take advantage of a reserved seat, the unscrupulous Folter makes Fekni—the illiterate wife of a Dalit labourer, Musba—a candidate for village head. Liquor, money and threats secure her victory. Thereafter Fekni remains a figurehead while Folter makes every financial decision. Government projects and MGNREGA funds are extensively misappropriated. When an inquiry takes place, Fekni reveals that she did nothing but affix her thumbprint to documents. Both Folter and Fekni are eventually arrested.

"Sahodarā" concerns the love between two brothers. After their parents

die, Janak raises and educates his younger brother Prem. Quarrels begin after marriage and the household is divided. With time, Prem prospers, while Janak falls into financial difficulty and becomes burdened by debt. One day Prem sees his brother working as a labourer and feels profound pain. In the end, he hands over his shop to Janak and resolves to reunite the family. The story emphasises sacrifice, fraternity and family bonds.

"Garībak Jingī" (A Poor Person's Life) portrays the exploitation and struggle of poor labourers through Bholta and his son Bantha. A landlord, Nunubabu, schemes to take Bantha out of school and employ him in his house; he refuses to raise wages even when prices rise. When Bantha protests, he is threatened. The poor organise and begin working in other villages, bringing the landlord's cultivation to a halt. In revenge, the landlord blocks a road and obstructs medical treatment for a patient, with the result that Bantha's younger brother dies. Later a false allegation of theft becomes the pretext for an attack on Bantha and Bholta; Bholta is killed. Bantha chooses not to resort to violence. He seeks legal redress and obtains justice.

"Śramdānī Bāndh" (The Voluntary-Labour Embankment) concerns a village's protective embankment during the rainy season. Heavy rainfall weakens it and the villagers seek help from the mukhiya, or elected village head. He publicly assures them that the administration will deal with the danger, but secretly hopes the embankment will collapse so that he can collect commissions and bribes from crop-loss compensation, relief payments and housing schemes. At night he has his henchmen cut through it. Floodwaters spread through the village, destroying homes, grain and livestock. Later the body of a young man is found in the water: he is the mukhiya's own son. Greed thus returns to him as personal bereavement.

"Dachhinwāri Ṭol" (The Southern Hamlet) describes a proposed national-highway development in Manikpur village. The road is diverted southwards to save the main village, but the house of Budhna Mallik in the southern hamlet is demolished. He receives no land compensation and rebuilds elsewhere. Upper-caste neighbours resent him because of his caste and accuse his wife of witchcraft. One night his house is set alight. The family escape, but, left without shelter, all four are crushed to death by a truck while sleeping beside the road. The story reveals the cruelty of caste hatred and inhumanity.

"Paglā Pul" (The Madman's Bridge) traces the fluctuations in the life of Vineet Das. Once a gifted student, he falls into bad company and addiction, loses all his land and becomes mentally disturbed. Ostracised by

his village, he lives by the river, earning what he can. One day a minister and some officials are imperilled when their boat sinks. The spectators merely watch, but Vineet—the supposedly "mad" man—dives into the river and saves all four lives. His courage becomes widely known, and treatment gradually restores his health. Offered a reward, he asks not for money but for a bridge across the river. In the end a bridge is built, and society comes to respect him anew.

"Vidhvā Vivāh" (Widow Remarriage) poignantly depicts Sushila's struggle. On the first night of her marriage her husband Rajiv dies from a snakebite, leaving her widowed at a young age. Humiliation in her marital home and social contempt break her spirit. Her father brings her back to her natal home, but the community refuses to countenance a widow's remarriage. In acute distress Sushila attempts suicide. A young engineer arrives in time to save her and offers to marry her. The story argues strongly for widow remarriage and human sympathy.

"Vṛddhāśram" (Old-Age Home) offers a sensitive portrayal of duty and ingratitude through Gopal Ji and his son Raman. Gopal Ji sells his land and works as a labourer to educate his son, who becomes a bank officer. After marriage Raman and Sulochana settle in the city for work. They regard the elderly parents as an inconvenience and send them to an old-age home rather than caring for them. Gopal Ji and his wife both die there. In time Raman and Sulochana are themselves sent to the same institution by their son. The story makes parental neglect return upon the next generation.

"Dostak Biāh" (A Friend's Wedding) vividly recounts friendship and an encounter with caste prejudice. The narrator and Mahesh have been close friends since childhood, studying and eating together. Years later Mahesh marries, and the narrator accompanies him as his close wedding companion, a lokaniyā. At the wedding procession, once his caste becomes known, the bride's family refuses to accept him in that ceremonial role. Humiliated, he returns home that very night. Mahesh and his family later apologise. The narrator eventually obtains a successful job and comes to feel that economic standing, more than caste, has become the determinant of respect in society.

"Mānavatāk Pūjārī" (A Worshipper of Humanity) powerfully presents greed, exploitation and moral transformation. Chunnilal Seth exploits the poor through usurious lending, while his son, Dr Shyam, earns money by ordering needless medical tests. Dr Vivek deliberately gives Shyam a false diagnosis of blood cancer to awaken his conscience. Afraid of death, father and son change their conduct: they forgive debts, assist the poor and begin

treating patients selflessly. Eventually they discover that the diagnosis was false; nevertheless the shock has led them to serve humanity. The story insists that true prestige lies not in wealth but in compassion and humanity.

"Bhagwanpur" offers an inspiring portrait of Bhagwan Lal Das's extraordinary public service and self-sacrificing life. Remaining unmarried, he devotes himself wholly to helping the poor with daughters' marriages, schooling, medical care and shelter. Even after becoming a Block Development Officer, he serves honestly and puts his income to public use. Eventually he establishes a school and devotes himself to expanding education. After his death, society's caste narrowness emerges once more when his cremation at the cremation ground is obstructed. Yet his service and sacrifice shake the community's conscience, and the village finally renames itself "Bhagwanpur" in his honour.

2

The very title Mujrim ("Culprit" or "Accused") deconstructs its established meaning. Ordinarily a mujrim is a person who commits a crime. In this collection, however, the word moves away from its conventional meaning to become a symbol of the cruelty of power and privilege. Those pushed to the social margins and subjected to exploitation are declared "criminals" by the system. Who, then, is the real culprit—the oppressed person upon whom the label is imposed, or the dominant order that determines who will bear it?

3

Those whom society regards as "inferior" or "impure" ultimately become indispensable to the supposedly "pure" centre. In "Solakanmā Pokhair," upper-caste people regard the pond of the Solakanma hamlet as untouchable and polluted. Yet when fire breaks out, water from this very "impure" pond saves the whole village, becoming life-giving and therefore "pure." The tale reverses the myths of untouchability and ritual purity, demonstrating how man-made social boundaries collapse in a crisis.

4

In "Girahat Ghar Par Giddh," upper-caste landlords imagine themselves the centre of authority and power. But when humiliated Dalits refuse to remove their dead livestock, vultures begin circling those "powerful" households and the landlords become helpless. The refusal to act by those kept on the margins paralyses the centre. In this way, the story deconstructs the hollowness of feudal authority and domination.

5

In "Paglā Pul," society regards Vineet Das, who survives beside the river, as mad and contemptible. On the other side stand ministers and officials, whom society considers "intellectual" and "civilised." But when their boat sinks, these supposedly capable people are helpless and it is Vineet, the "madman," who jumps into the river and saves them. The wall separating sanity and madness crumbles, and the man called mad teaches society a lesson in humanity.

6

In "Tetar Das," a boy denounced as "Lūṭnā," an ill omen, becomes a formidable Sanskrit scholar and saint. Thousands are moved by his discourses. Yet when the time comes for him to become a mahant, caste outweighs learning. The story deconstructs institutional religion's claim to spiritual equality, showing how birth is given greater authority than merit.

7

Umesh Paswan's Mujrim is not merely a lament over Dalit oppression. It breaks apart from within the linguistic and ideological structures that produce marginalisation and exclusion. The text reveals that the social centre depends for its existence upon the very periphery it despises.

8

"Kodāri Chhāp" (The Spade Symbol) is extraordinarily moving and politically important. Reserving a seat in a panchayat election for a Dalit woman ought to mark a democratic victory and the empowerment of an oppressed group. Yet the story unsettles that promise. The reserved seat does not give the Dalit woman Fekni power; instead, she becomes a puppet in the hands of the dominant and intimidating Folter. Behind the appearance of democracy is a new feudalism: rather than rule openly, the exploitative class rules through a Dalit figurehead. Supposed "empowerment" generates a new form of exploitation.

The election symbol, the spade, signifies the working class, labour, sweat and soil. It is the true emblem of Musba and his wife Fekni, the exploited labourers. In order to win the election, however, the spade symbol becomes detached from its original meaning. A tool once used to dig the soil becomes the emblem of fraud and the diversion of lakhs of rupees from MGNREGA schemes. Folter, the exploiter, hijacks the sign of the exploited for his own benefit.

At the end, a corruption inquiry leads to the arrest of Folter and Fekni alike. This is presented as proof that "the law is equal for everyone." But is

Fekni truly a criminal? She cannot read or write; her husband Musba, caught in a web of liquor and inducements, puts her forward as the candidate; she has merely placed her thumbprint upon papers. The justice system weighs Folter, the mastermind, and Fekni, the victim, on the same scale. Deconstruction reveals that such "justice" may be profoundly unjust, because it treats ignorance and structural helplessness themselves as "crimes."

Folter's feudal mentality makes him look down upon a poor labourer such as Musba. Yet to gain power and occupy the position of village head, Folter must depend entirely upon that Dalit labourer and his wife, on those he relegates to the periphery. The key to the powerful Folter's authority is in the hands of a poor, uneducated Dalit woman. The presumed balance between exploiter and exploited is thus destabilised.

"Kodāri Chhāp" demonstrates that so long as economic and educational inequality persist—as in Musba's poverty and Fekni's illiteracy—political reservation by itself cannot achieve genuine change. The story depicts both the cunning of the exploitative class and the hollowness of the legal order.

9

"Sahodarā" narrates the division and eventual reunion of two brothers amid blood ties and economic insecurity. It affirms the proposition that "brothers of the same blood remain brothers." Janak raises his younger brother Prem almost as a father would. When Janak falls into poverty and labours for a living, the now prosperous Prem gives him his shop. This is an idealised and sentimental victory of fraternal love. But a major patriarchal contradiction lies hidden in the tale. The entire blame for the household's division is placed upon Janak's wife. Society often overlooks the economic causes of family breakdown and calls the woman a "home-breaker" or a source of discord. Prem's apparent greatness, moreover, depends on his prosperity. Had his land not fallen within the route of the national highway and had he not been able to open a shop with the compensation, could he have rescued his brother so readily? Unwittingly, the story shows that even greatness and sacrifice require "capital."

10

"Vidhvā Vivāh" (Widow Remarriage) is a tale of women's struggle and the myth of the "male saviour." It recounts the hardships and eventual remarriage of Sushila, widowed at a young age. Society is exceedingly cruel to widows: her mother-in-law calls her a witch and an ill omen, while others cast predatory glances at her yet refuse to accept her. The story challenges this injustice by portraying a progressive young engineer who accepts Sushila as an ideal. Yet at the beginning Sushila's physical beauty—

fair skin, large eyes and long hair—is described at length and she is called a "dream girl." Had she been unattractive or ordinary-looking, would the engineer have saved her and proposed marriage? Her "value" is still determined by her body and appearance. Driven to attempt suicide, she must be rescued by a "capable man." She does not become self-reliant and confront society on her own; her deliverance consists in passing from one man's protection to another's. Thus, despite its progressivism, the story fails to overcome the patriarchal opposition between the "helpless woman" and the "protective man."

II

"Śramdānī Bāndh" offers an exceptionally sharp criticism of contemporary politics, institutional corruption and "disaster capitalism." Villagers bring their fear of an embankment collapse to the mukhiya because he is their elected representative and protector. He assures them that he will summon the Block Development Officer and Circle Officer and get the embankment repaired. The story, however, shows state power, represented by the village head, acting not to protect citizens but to exploit them. He prevents the villagers from reinforcing the embankment with earth. The "protector" proves to be a "devourer": under cover of darkness he orders his henchmen to cut through the embankment. This thoroughly deconstructs the promise of political representation in democracy.

Politically, the tale exposes the cruellest form of turning "disaster" into "opportunity" within a neoliberal economy. For the mukhiya, the destruction of the village is not a tragedy but a "project." He openly reasons that unless the embankment breaks, houses will not fall; and unless houses fall, there will be no scope for him to earn commissions from housing assistance, crop-loss payments and relief. Human pain and devastation are being converted directly into financial profit. The story shows how in a corrupt system "destruction" becomes the prerequisite for "development."

The name "Śramdānī Bāndh" (Voluntary-Labour Embankment) is deeply symbolic. Śramdān signifies the collective strength, self-reliance and solidarity of ordinary people. When the ruler orders the embankment cut, he destroys not simply an earthen wall but the people's collective labour and independence. Power does not want people to be self-sufficient; it wants them homeless and dependent upon the authorities for relief and housing grants.

The mukhiya's greed brings him to have the embankment cut, and eventually his own son Amit drowns in the floodwaters. This is the story's message of karmaphala, the fruit of action. Intoxicated by power and

privilege, the mukhiya believes himself immune from the destructive system he has engineered. He imagines that floodwaters will drown only "the poor." But the alliance of a natural disaster and a corrupt administration is blind; the exploiter who digs a pit for others must eventually discover the limits of his imagined safety. The mukhiya's authority proves helpless before nature and the consequences of his actions.

"Śramdānī Bāndh" is therefore not merely the story of an individual corrupt village head's downfall. It calls the whole "system" to account. It reveals how institutional greed puts ordinary lives at risk, and how the centre of power finally becomes entangled in the trap of its own making.

12

Umesh Paswan's stories paint a realistic and moving picture of society. Their analysis also reveals, however, that traditional prejudices and economic realities may remain concealed even within apparently reformist visions of social progress.

31. “Diyari”: A Comprehensive Literary Evaluation of R. N. Sudhakar’s Short-Story Collection

Abstract

A Multidimensional Review of R. N. Sudhakar’s Maithili Short-Story Collection. Diyari (a Maithili short-story collection), written by Ramnarayan Sudhakar (R. N. Sudhakar), is an important document of Maithili literature centred on Biratnagar, Nepal. The publisher’s note records that the author has been writing for nearly sixty years but remained largely invisible to the literary world for want of publication, publicity and circulation. The collection received the Nepal Vidyapith Maithili Manuscript Award, 2065.

Keywords: Diyari · Sudhakar · Collection · Comprehensive · Literary · Evaluation · Stories

Diyari: A Comprehensive Literary Evaluation

A Multidimensional Review of R. N. Sudhakar’s Maithili Short-Story Collection

Preliminary Observations: The Book’s Character and Importance

Diyari (a Maithili short-story collection), written by Ramnarayan Sudhakar (R. N. Sudhakar), is an important document of Maithili literature centred on Biratnagar, Nepal. The publisher’s note records that the author has been writing for nearly sixty years but remained largely invisible to the literary world because his work lacked publication, publicity and circulation. The collection received the Nepal Vidyapith Maithili Manuscript Award, 2065. The volume brings together twenty-two stories.

Part One: Structural Analysis of the Collection

1.1 Geographical and Cultural Setting

Sudhakar’s fictional world is centred principally on three geographical regions:

(a) The border area (the Jogbani–Biratnagar frontier): Stories such as “Sandhi,” “Khutti Par Tangal Bra” and “Chan Asothakit Achhi” present this frontier’s complex socioeconomic environment. The author himself pursued his literary vocation while living in this border area, a fact reflected in the authenticity of the stories.

(b) Rural Mithila: “Pradakshina,” “Jhakharal Phulak Gachh,” “Sunagait Karej,” “Thakuchal Masuk Butti” and other stories offer detailed pictures of rural Maithil life—ponds, wells, the sacred basil courtyard, the scent of

earth and mustard flowers. These images of remembrance express the nostalgia of a displaced soul.

(c) The urban environment (Biratnagar): "Diyari," "Gharmunha," "Chilhori Uri Rahal Achhi," "Nukka Chori" and "Karjakhor" focus on the struggles of industrial urban life, economic pressure and the fragmentation of families.

1.2 Chronology and Period of Composition

The stories in the collection were composed across a wide span of time: 1976–77 CE.

This span (1976–2020, or forty-four years) reveals the length and continuity of Sudhakar's literary journey. The development of a storyteller can be observed within the collection itself.

Part Two: Detailed Reviews of the Stories

2.1 "Pradakshina" (Circumambulation): Memory, Displacement and the Death of the Village

Plot: After living away for twelve years, a man named Bachanu returns to his village and is shocked to discover how completely it has changed. The villagers have become strangers, friends have forgotten him, the pond has dried up and the bhalsari tree has been uprooted.

Detailed Analysis:

The story inhabits a world of feeling reminiscent of Thomas Hardy's *The Return of the Native*: a confrontation between the person who returns and the landscape transformed in his absence. Yet Sudhakar's vision is more poignant. Bachanu left his village out of economic necessity; when he returned, the village's soul had died.

The story's most moving passage describes Bachanu feeling as though his village had been left behind somewhere, his friends had become ghostlike somewhere, the bhalsari blossoms had been scattered somewhere; he himself stood stock-still, like the long, sharp thorn of a shani tree in a desolate wilderness.

The mythic dimension: Circumambulation is a significant symbol in the story. In Hindu tradition, walking around a village or temple is an auspicious act. Here, however, Bachanu's circumambulation of his village becomes a funeral procession: he circles a past that no longer exists.

From the perspective of Indian poetics: *Karuṇa rasa*, the aesthetic sentiment of pathos, predominates; yet *vipralambha śṛṅgāra*, the pain of

separation, also flows beneath it—in Bachanu's estrangement from the friends of his childhood.

2.2 "Diyari": Women's Identity amid Family Pressures

Plot: A middle-class family is bound by complicated relationships among an elderly father-in-law, the ailing wife Sushila and her husband, the story's first-person narrator. The elderly father-in-law seeks financial freedom, Sushila lives in pain, and the husband is crushed by pressure from both sides.

Detailed Analysis:

The title "Diyari"—a tract of land surrounded by currents of water from both sides—is a precise metaphor. The husband resembles such an island, caught between pressures advancing from opposite directions.

The story's most moving passage:

The lantern flares brightly. On one side stands the palace of Sushila's aspirations; on the other, the flickering lamp of an old man's paternal affection. Can that lamp burn inside the palace? Neither does the palace appeal to the old man, nor does Sushila wish to shelter the lamp within it.

A psychoanalytic perspective: Viewed through Sigmund Freud's Oedipus complex, Sushila's psychological conflict with her father-in-law introduces a subtle psychic layer. Sudhakar, however, does not portray the situation as mysterious or sensational; he presents it as an ordinary complexity of family life.

Women's discourse: Sushila is the story's central force, but hers is a silent force. Her illness, her helpless position and her husband's powerlessness form a triangle that makes the narrative an authentic document of women's suffering.

2.3 "Choliya Me Chor Base Gori": Rural Youth and the Language of the Body

Plot: Two young women, Samtoliya and Vilta, become immersed in love, jealousy, attraction and the energy of youth while cutting grass.

Detailed Analysis:

Published in the magazine *Mati-Pani* in March 1984, this story has an open narrative structure that does not feel stale. Like D. H. Lawrence's depictions of rural youth, it is uninhibited and closely connected to nature.

The story's beauty is captured in these lines: on one side, the embankment was fragrant as far as the eye could see with the yellow blossoms of

mustard; on the other, towering, jointed sugarcane stalks, intoxicated by their own sweetness, bent and swayed in wild luxuriance.

Nature is not merely a background but a force that affects the characters: the fertility of nature and the fertility of youth become one.

The folkloric context: The story's title is itself a line from a folk song. Sudhakar weaves the folk tradition naturally into a modern narrative.

A feminist perspective: The relationship between Vilta and Samtoliya displays a strong female bond, one often overlooked in male-centred literature.

2.4 "Khutti Par Tangal Bra" (A Bra Hanging on a Peg): Consumerism and the Female Body

Plot: Buchiya goes into a shop. Gangba, the shopkeeper, shows her various articles and finally gives her a bra (brassiere). Buchiya's inner conflict—between economic constraint and bodily need—lies at the centre of the story.

Detailed Analysis:

Written in October 1984, this story was extraordinarily bold for its time. No other Maithili writer of that period addressed this particular subject.

A critique of market culture: The story presents a criticism of the marketplace.

Gangba embodies market culture: he views the female body through a commercial lens.

A Marxist perspective: The commodification of the female body is the story's central theme. Buchiya's economic vulnerability traps her in Gangba's net. Class exploitation and gender exploitation operate together.

Foucault: Michel Foucault observed that "power operates on the body." In this story, Gangba's gaze, his "commercial smile," and finally the bra hanging on the peg are all visible expressions of relations of power.

In the final line, her gaze comes to rest on the hanging brassiere. She feels as if she herself has filled its two cups with what is compressed inside her and hung them there with her own hands. The line gives expression to a woman's helpless condition and the merciless nature of the market.

2.5 "Chan Asothakit Achhi" (The Moon Is Restless/Weary): Old Age, Desire and Social Hypocrisy

Plot: Sushil Babu is elderly and suffers from breathlessness, yet Maya, who cares for him, continues to arouse him. Maya herself suffers sexual

frustration: her husband Mantunma is almost impotent. Eventually Sushil Babu appoints Mantunma as a new *sutanahar* (watchman).

Detailed Analysis:

The story occupies an exceptionally complex psychological terrain. "Chan Asothakit Achhi"—the moon is unsettled or exhausted—is itself a title charged with erotic suggestion.

Simone de Beauvoir: In one sense Maya represents de Beauvoir's "second sex." Her bodily needs are dependent on a male-centred arrangement. Her eagerness and agitation are human expressions suppressed by society.

Old age and sexual desire: Literature frequently portrays the desires of older people as laughable or reprehensible. Sudhakar approaches the subject with compassion and sympathy. Sushil Babu's breathlessness is not merely a physical symptom; it is also a tragic experience of old age.

Moral complexity: The moral framework is not simple. Sudhakar views Maya's self-sacrifice and the other elements of the situation with sympathy rather than condemnation.

2.6 "Jhakharal Phulak Gachh" (The Uprooted Flowering Tree): Polygamy and Women's Suffering

Plot: Jivachha, Khanjaniya and Phuliya are the principal figures. Jivachha maintains an illicit relationship with his stepmother Khanjaniya. The conflict between the two women and Jivachha's moral decline are exposed.

Detailed Analysis:

The story was written on 14 November 1976. Chronologically it is one of Sudhakar's earliest pieces, yet the boldness of its subject is unparalleled.

Khanjaniya's character: Khanjaniya gives the story its power. She says, "Do not separate me from Jivachha ... I shall lie in some corner." This line exposes a woman's helplessness: economic, social and psychological dependence keep her bound.

The symbolic significance of the elderly Khanjaniya: Phuliya uproots old Khanjaniya, Jivachha's stepmother, as mercilessly as a flowering tree torn from the ground, and casts her into the courtyard.

The aptness of the title: "Jhakharal Phulak Gachh" is a beautiful metaphor for old age and abandonment.

2.7 "Gharmunha": Urban Isolation and Family Disintegration

Plot: The narrator, a husband, and his wife live in a small room in Biratnagar. Their struggles, economic deprivation, the wife's illness and the husband's psychological suffering form the story's substance.

Detailed Analysis:

The struggle of an entire family is portrayed through only a handful of images.

The image of the cooking stove: The pot of rice and lentils on the stove in the room, "potatoes and arikonch greens covered in a metal vessel," and the plates and bowls on the bench are not merely an inventory of objects. They are visible signs of a life spent struggling.

A crisis of identity: The narrator can neither understand, enjoy nor make himself at home in urban life; nor can he forget the fragrance of his rural soil or free himself from its moist, clinging texture. This is a common experience of Maithils settled in Biratnagar.

2.8 "Upahar" (The Gift): Modern Women's Suffering through the Symbol of Yashodhara

Plot: Yashodhara's husband Gautam has fled the home. Recriminations, the family's expectations and her loneliness are portrayed.

Detailed Analysis:

Mythic context: Sudhakar reinterprets the story of Yashodhara and Gautama Buddha in a modern setting. Gautam, a modern man, pursues his ideals and leaves Yashodhara—and their Rahul—behind.

Irony: At the end, Yashodhara takes the child Rahul into her arms: "Gautam's first and last gift." The line is ironic: a man's supreme "gift" is a child.

2.9 "Chilhori Uri Rahal Achhi": Unemployment, Marriage and Betrayal by Friends

Plot: Vinod is unemployed. Chanda's conduct hurts him; in his period of unemployment, he experiences neglect and betrayal by a friend.

Detailed Analysis:

Economic impotence and masculine identity: In a patriarchal society, a man's identity is tied to his earnings. Vinod's unemployment is not merely a financial problem. His masculine pride, public standing and "value" in his wife's eyes are threatened together.

Chanda's character: Chanda is not one-dimensional and is no villain. Her demands and dissatisfaction are human responses to a system that regards women's dreams and aspirations as frivolous. In the end, however, her behaviour breaks Vinod.

The story's title, "Chilhori Uri Rahal Achhi," is a metaphor for Vinod's life, flying without support.

2.10 "Nukka Chori": Forbidden Love and Social Barriers

Plot: Chandan and Vibha are young people connected through a *pahun* relationship; the structure of kinship renders their love "illicit."

Detailed Analysis:

The complexity of relationships: Romantic feelings are considered forbidden within a relationship such as *pahun*. Yet Chandan and Vibha's attraction crosses this barrier.

Chandan's conflict: This is a genuine emotional connection that goes against the social structure.

A balance between romanticism and realism: Sudhakar neither glorifies nor condemns the relationship. He shows only the agitation of two human hearts.

2.11 "Karjakhor" (The Debt-Ridden Man): Debt Traps and Middle-Class Torment

Plot: Dasji is an unemployed middle-class man who has borrowed from several people: Dhruvji, 1,500; Gopal, involving a pillow, bedding and a sheet; Virendra, 500; Umashankarji, 400; Pradip, 590; and Harishankarji, approximately 1,700. This inventory of debts expresses the pathos of his life.

Detailed Analysis:

Realistic detail: The schedule of debts is a literary device. A list compiled with pen and paper becomes an account of one person's entire struggle to live.

The episode involving Pradip: The relationship between Pradip, who behaves rather like a moneylender, and Dasji is moving. Pradip says, "Look, Dasji, for you this sum is no great mountain … Pay it a little attention and you'll be able to arrange it." The line reveals a complicated power dynamic in which the debtor's dignity is gradually eroded.

Marx: Debt is a chain by which capitalist society makes a middle-class person captive. Dasji's predicament is a literary example of "debt bondage."

2.12 "Rampari": The Epistolary Form and Women's Inner Conflicts

Plot: The narrator, a young woman named Suryamukhi, writes a letter to her friend Rampari, referring to her own life.

Detailed Analysis:

The epistolary form: The story is written in the epistolary mode, a relatively rare experiment in Maithili fiction. The language of a letter carries an intimacy and informality different from straightforward narration.

The inclusion of a song: A song appears midway through the narrative, lending it an additional emotional dimension. The mingling of song and story is an old tradition in Indian literature.

The date 28 August 1976: The letter ends with "Your Suryamukhi (28.8.76)." The date turns the story into a historical document.

2.13 "Astitva" (Existence): Three Brothers, an Elderly Father and a Property Dispute

Plot: Three brothers—Shrikant, Shashikant and Sudhakant—and their aged father are at the centre of the narrative. The father's care, the daily arrangements for meals and a tendency towards separation under the influence of their wives become points of tension.

Detailed Analysis:

The disintegration of the joint family: "Astitva" narrates the breakdown of the joint-family system. All three brothers, under pressure from their respective wives, are thinking about setting up separate homes.

The old man's painful predicament: The elderly father, lying on a trunk, suddenly becomes alert. This single small detail conveys the entire psychology of the relationship between father and sons.

Satirical criticism: The story, with its image of chewing jaggery and rice, draws a satirical portrait.

2.14 "Sunagait Karaj": Child Psychology and the Adult World

Plot: Maheshwa, a small boy, leaves school and plays in an orchard, and so on.

Detailed Analysis:

The child's perspective: Sudhakar reveals the psychology of childhood with exceptional sensitivity. Maheshwa's hunger, curiosity, "rebellion" and smoking of a bidi establish the child as a complete human being.

The coin offered to Mahadeva: Maheshwa sees some money placed on the Śiva-liṅga and takes it. The scene has a profound symbolic meaning.

2.15 "Thakuchal Masuk Butti": Art, Youth and Society's Violence

Plot: Lalanma, a gifted flautist and singer, has been the narrator's friend since childhood. Gradually, however, Lalan takes the path of violence.

Detailed Analysis:

The tragic destiny of an artist: Society does not nurture Lalan's talent for the flute; it destroys it. The story poses the question: what sort of society compels its gifted children to become violent?

Lalan and the narrator: Roasted grains cupped in the hands, and song.

2.16 "Khandit Lok" (A Fragmented World): Generational Conflict and the Clash between Tradition and Modernity

Plot: A generational struggle unfolds between the elderly Lalchan and his family. Lalchan lived by the ideals he found in Premchand, Sarat Chandra and Jaishankar Prasad, but his family rejects those values.

Detailed Analysis:

The episode with the fish: The old man buys fish and brings it home. His wife exclaims, "Oh dear! Who will cook fish at this late hour of the evening?" It is an ordinary domestic incident, but two generations and two worlds collide within it.

Idealism and realism: Literary idealism had been the old man's sustaining provision for life. Yet what use are those fragrant ideals if nobody understands them? There is the reality of modern life. The old man is isolated between the two.

2.17 "Chhagar" (Goat): Multiple Relationships and Women's Resistance

Plot: Chandan and Rupam, also called Rupa, are married. Chandan's mother, Rupam's mother-in-law, continually torments her. At last Rupam gives voice to her resistance.

Detailed Analysis:

The title "Chhagar" is a satirical symbol. A goat is reared for sacrifice; similarly, Rupa is like a sacrificial animal in her marital home.

The relationship between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law: This relationship recurs throughout Indian literature. Sudhakar, however, neither makes the mother-in-law a villain nor casts Rupa as solely a victim. Chandan, the husband, stands somewhere between them, but his silence is also a form of complicity in oppression.

2.18 "Parivesh" (Milieu): Politics, Personal Ambition and Moral Decline

Plot: Bachcha Bhai, an influential villager, comes into conflict with Manohar's educated family. A young man, Chandrakant, becomes embroiled in the quarrel and is beaten by men belonging to Bachcha Bhai's faction.

Detailed Analysis:

Political satire: Published in the January 1991 issue of *Sanket*, issued from Janakpur, the story is set against the years preceding democratic change in Nepal. Bachcha Bhai's enjoyment of power and rural political intrigue reflect that historical period.

2.19 "Chhahari Tarak Kant" (A Thorn beneath the Shade): Brotherhood, Women and Justice

Plot: The relationship between Shashikant and Hemkant is central. Sumitra, Shashikant's wife, and Shyama, Hemkant's wife, are the two women. There is a property dispute and a slap.

Detailed Analysis:

The metaphor of the cucumber: Two cucumbers growing from the same seed, in the same soil, with the support of the same bamboo, mature side by side—yet their kinship breaks. It is a poignant image of fractured brotherhood.

2.20 "Sandhi" (Treaty): The Border Area and a Thunderbolt Striking Both Men

A playful man speaks in Kabirdas's idiom, and the effect on the two men is like a thunderbolt. Both earn their livelihood; yet on the twenty-seventh day they reconcile. Twenty-nine days have passed since the India–Nepal treaty was broken.

2.21 "Swapna-Bhang" (The Shattering of a Dream): Love, Imagination and the Struggle with Reality

Plot: Shrikant is attached to Padma. His account is an interior monologue resembling a diary.

Detailed Analysis: This is the collection's most Romantic story in its mode of narration. The very title, "The Shattering of a Dream," invokes an important theme of the Romantic movement.

2.22 "Kono Ek Din" (One Day): The COVID-19 Pandemic and Human Isolation

Written on 3 October 2020, the story takes the form of a night-time conversation between husband and wife during the COVID lockdown. Memories of the past and dissatisfaction with the present emerge.

Detailed Analysis:

This is the collection's only story to record the experience of the pandemic. Its closing line—"It was a full-moon night that day …"—expresses the return of past memory to the present.

Part Three: Analysis in the Light of Gangesha Upadhyaya's Navya-Nyāya

3.1 Foundational Concepts of Navya-Nyāya

The *Tattvacintāmaṇi* of Gangesha Upadhyaya, the Mithila philosopher active around 1320 CE, is a foundational text of Navya-Nyāya philosophy. Its principal concepts and means of cognition include:

Vyāpti—universal concomitance

Anumāna—inference

Śabda—verbal testimony

Pratyakṣa—direct perception

Upādhi—a condition or qualifier

These are major means or principles of knowledge.

3.2 A Navya-Nyāya Analysis of "Diyari"

In relation to *vyāpti* (universal relation): In Navya-Nyāya, *vyāpti* signifies an invariable relation, as in "Where there is smoke, there is fire." Sudhakar's stories reveal a pervasive relation:

Where there is economic deprivation, there is family disintegration.

This relationship appears consistently in "Karjakhor," "Gharmunha," "Diyari" and "Chilhori Uri Rahal Achhi." From the Navya-Nyāya perspective, that pervasive pattern is the foundation of Sudhakar's literary worldview.

In relation to *anumāna* (inference): Navya-Nyāya distinguishes three forms of inference—*kevalānvayin*, *kevalavyatirekin* and *anvayavyatirekin*. Sudhakar's characters draw conclusions through inference, but these inferences are frequently misleading; sometimes they prove mistaken. [Story: "Parivesh."]

In relation to *upādhi* (condition): In Navya-Nyāya an *upādhi* is a qualification that restricts a purported universal relation. In "Nukka Chori," social conditions are imposed upon Chandan and Vibha's love and declare it "illicit." Such conditional restraints recur throughout Sudhakar's fiction.

Part Four: Analysis within the Videha Parallel-History Framework

4.1 The Videha Tradition and Mithila's Literature

"Videha" is an ancient name of Mithila. King Janaka's kingdom of Videha symbolises Mithila's civilisation. The "Videha history framework" seeks to recover the parallel history of Maithils living in Nepal's Tarai: a history commonly overlooked in official national narratives.

4.2 Sudhakar's Stories and Videha History

Sudhakar was born in Malhani, Kalaiya (Birgunj), Nepal, and later settled in Biratnagar. This migrant-Maithil experience constitutes a parallel history:

(a) Maithil identity on the India–Nepal border:

The Nepal–India oil treaty in "Sandhi" is not merely an element of plot; it is the living history of a Maithil community situated, like a *diyari*, between two countries. [Border area.]

(b) Nepal's political transformations and the Maithils:

The shadow of Nepal's democratic movement and Maoist struggle is clearly present in "Parivesh" and "Khandit Lok." These stories document the effects of political upheaval on Maithil society.

(c) Linguistic identity:

Writing in Maithili is itself a political act where the language has been marginalised. Sudhakar's sixty years of literary work constitute a chapter in this "linguistic resistance."

Part Five: Overall Assessment through Indian, Chinese and Western Theories

5.1 From the Perspective of Indian Poetics

Rasa Theory (Bharata Muni, approximately 300 BCE):

Story — Predominant Rasa

"Pradakshina" — *Karuṇa* + *Bībhatsa*

"Diyari" — *Karuṇa* + *Śānta*

"Jhakharal Phulak Gachh" — *Karuṇa + Raudra*

"Choliya Me Chor Base Gori" — *Śṛṅgāra*

"Upahar" — *Karuṇa + Vīra*

"Karjakhor" — *Karuṇa*

"Thakuchal Masuk Butti" — *Karuṇa + Raudra*

The sentiment of compassion or pathos, *karuṇa rasa*, is the strongest in Sudhakar's stories. In Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra*, the abiding emotion underlying *karuṇa rasa* is *śoka* (grief). Abhinavagupta maintained that this sentiment becomes possible when the reader or spectator, through *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* (universalisation), recognises the self in a character's suffering. Sudhakar achieves this universalisation with remarkable success: readers can recognise themselves in the distress of Dasji, Vinod, Bachanu and Lalan.

Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana, approximately ninth century):

Suggestion, or *dhvani*, is exceedingly powerful in Sudhakar's stories. The title "Diyari" itself carries suggested meanings: a river island, a husband's predicament and the uncertainty surrounding a woman's identity are all evoked simultaneously.

"Khutti Par Tangal Bra" likewise contains a suggested meaning that conveys both "market-oriented civilisation" and the "commodification of the female body."

Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka, approximately tenth century):

Kuntaka's *vakrokti*—oblique or distinctive expression—is readily visible in Sudhakar's language. He uses obliqueness at the level of the word (*pada-vakratā*), sentence (*vākya-vakratā*) and overall composition (*prabandha-vakratā*).

5.2 From the Perspective of Chinese Literary Theory

Liu Xie (465–521 CE), *Wenxin Diaolong*—"The Literary Mind and the Carving of Dragons":

For Liu Xie, fine literature brings together both *Qíng* (feeling) and *Lǐ* (reason or principle).

Sudhakar's fiction offers a beautiful conjunction of the two:

Qíng: the emotional authenticity of his characters.

Lǐ: the rational depiction of social problems.

The Aesthetics of Su Shi (1037–1101):

Su Shi said that literary truth emerges from nature. This "natural truth" is strongly evident in Sudhakar's stories. Avoiding artificial language and an entangled narrative mechanism, he grasps the truth of life directly.

Bi and *Xing*: Metaphorical Principles in Chinese Poetics

Bi means simile or metaphor, and *xing* an arousal of feeling. Both are prominently present in Sudhakar's stories:

"Diyari" (*bi*): a river island in the midst of water = the predicament of husband and wife.

"Jhakharal Phulak Gachh" (*bi*): an uprooted tree = an abandoned elderly woman.

"Sunagait Karaj" (*xing*): the smouldering heart or debt arouses emotion.

5.3 From the Perspective of Western Theory

Mikhail Bakhtin (1895–1975): Dialogism and Polyphony

Bakhtin argued that the great novel—and literature more broadly—contains many voices, or *polyphony*: the author's is not the sole voice; different characters' voices sound together.

This polyphony is apparent in Sudhakar's stories:

In "Diyari," there are three voices—the elderly man, Sushila and her husband, the narrator. Each viewpoint is valid.

In "Astitva," the three brothers speak in three different voices.

In "Gharmunha," domestic life contains many unexpected voices.

Georg Lukács (1885–1971): Critical Realism

Lukács developed the theory of "critical realism," which reveals the contradictions of bourgeois society through truthful artistic representation.

In this sense Sudhakar is a critical realist. He neither writes propaganda for socialist realism nor retreats into escapism. Like a skilled surgeon, he lays bare the contradictions of the Maithil middle class.

Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937): Hegemony and the Organic Intellectual

Gramsci's concepts of "hegemony" and "organic intellectuals" illuminate Sudhakar, who is an organic intellectual expressing the experience of working people from within their own social world.

He worked in Biratnagar's industrial region. His struggles in life give his writing an organic authenticity.

Homi Bhabha (born 1949): The Third Space and Cultural Hybridity

Bhabha argued that colonialism—and displacement—produces a "Third Space," an identity that is neither wholly old nor wholly new.

Sudhakar, a Maithil of Nepal, inhabits this "Third Space." His characters —Bachna in "Pradakshina," the narrators of "Gharmunha" and "Sandhi"—suffer the disquiet of hybrid identity. "I could neither seize the moment to enter the turbulence of urban life … nor forget the fragrance of my rural soil": this is a literary expression of Bhabha's Third Space.

Part Six: Analysis of Language, Style and Technique

6.1 The Use of Maithili

Sudhakar employs a distinctive variety of Nepalese Maithili. It contains:

– An eastern dialect of Maithili.

– Certain words influenced by Nepali.

– The influence of the market speech of Biratnagar.

– The folk speech of rural Mithila.

6.2 Descriptive Style

Sudhakar's descriptions are economical. For example: "The pot of rice and lentils on the stove … the vessel of milk on the shelf … potatoes and arikonch greens covered in a metal dish, and their smell … the plates, bowls and glasses clustered on the bench … chutney of tomatoes, chillies and coriander crushed and heaped on the grinding stone … and, above all, a burning lamp, as though a flame were rising from someone's funeral pyre in the loneliness of a cremation ground."

These details produce an imagist effect.

6.3 The Style of Dialogue

Sudhakar's dialogue is exceptionally natural and alive. It is not unnecessarily "literary." For example, the dialogue in "Karjakhor" is a precise transcription of conversation in an ordinary Maithil family.

Part Seven: Overall Literary Evaluation

7.1 Sudhakar's Strengths

(a) Authenticity: Sudhakar's greatest strength is his authenticity. He writes what he has lived, seen and experienced. This "lived experience" distinguishes his stories from, and places them above, artificially manufactured literary fiction.

(b) Social commitment: He writes about social inequality, the exploitation of women and economic deprivation without ideological prejudice. He offers neither "communist" propaganda nor "Hindu conservative" moral sermons. He simply depicts human beings in all their complexity.

(c) Portrayal of women: Sudhakar's female characters are powerful and multidimensional. Sushila, Khanjaniya, Maya, Rupa, Yashodhara, Samtali and Vibha are real women—neither idealised goddesses nor "fallen women."

(d) The soil of language: His language carries the scent of Maithili soil. Instead of putting on a show of "pure Maithili," he writes in living Maithili.

7.2 Sudhakar's Limitations

(a) Plot structure: In some stories, such as "Swapna-Bhang," the plot structure becomes loose. The diary format does not always cohere.

(b) Centrality of male narrators: Most of the narrators are male, even though the female characters are exceptionally strong.

(c) Absence of resolution: Some stories, such as "Karjakhor," are left without a clear resolution. This is defensible from a realist perspective but can at times frustrate the reader.

Part Eight: A Comparative Perspective

8.1 Place within the Maithili Literary Tradition

Sudhakar's fiction appears to have been influenced by Harimohan Jha (satire), Lalit (the novel and short story), Rajkamal Chaudhary (modern prose) and Manipadma (realist fiction), yet he has developed his own original voice.

His position within the Nepalese Maithili short-story tradition is distinctive: he brought into literature the experiences of Biratnagar's "border area," experiences not otherwise available.

8.2 Comparison with Hindi Literature

A comparison may be drawn with Premchand (1880–1936): both wrote about the rural-to-urban transition and were sensitive to socioeconomic problems. Sudhakar, however, is bolder than Premchand in addressing sexuality.

A comparison with Mohan Rakesh (1925–1972) reveals themes shared by both: the discontent of the urban middle class and family disintegration. Sudhakar's language, however, is more deeply rooted in the soil.

Epilogue: A Comprehensive Judgement

"Diyari" is a priceless treasure of Maithili literature. Across six decades of writing, R. N. Sudhakar has created a literary world that is:

– In authenticity, rooted in Mithila's soil.

– In social responsibility, on the side of the poor, the neglected and the exploited.

– In its consciousness of women, ahead of its time (1976–2020).

– In linguistic beauty, living and fresh.

From the perspective of *vyāpti* in Navya-Nyāya: "Wherever there is a Sudhakar story, there is human truth." From the historical perspective of the Videha tradition, this collection is a living document of the Maithil people of Nepal's Tarai. From the perspective of Indian rasa theory, it is an intense cultivation of *karuṇa rasa*. From the Chinese *Qíng–Lǐ* perspective, it is a beautiful conjunction of emotion and truth. From the Western perspective of critical realism, it speaks the truth of an organic intellectual.

This collection has received a broad welcome within parallel Maithili literary circles. Such a welcome should come not only from Maithili readers but from the entire literary community of India and Nepal.

"Diyari"—situated amid the waves approaching from two sides—resembles Sudhakar's own literature: between tradition and modernity, village and city, the Maithili and Nepali worlds, yet steadfast in its originality.

32. A Critical Review of Parmeshwar Kapari's Tales and Folk Narratives

Abstract

Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti • Navya-Nyāya (Gangesha Upadhyaya) • Videha Parallel History. Parmeshwar Kapari, a senior Maithili writer from Janakpurdham, is known chiefly as a playwright. Yet his creative world also contains a rich body of stories and folk narratives that has not received the critical attention it deserves. Kapari's narrative world can principally be divided into four streams: (a) folk tales in their pure form, exemplified by "Lachhminiya Kaniya" and "Hanuman Nam Smaranke Mahima."

Keywords: Parmeshwar · Kapari · Tales · Critical · Review · Maithili · Kapari

A Critical Review of Parmeshwar Kapari's Tales and Folk Narratives

Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti • Navya-Nyāya (Gangesha Upadhyaya) • Videha Parallel History

Introduction: Parmeshwar Kapari as a Storyteller

Parmeshwar Kapari, a senior Maithili literary figure resident in Janakpurdham, is chiefly known as a playwright. But his oeuvre includes a rich world of tales and folk narratives that has not yet received adequate critical attention.

Kapari's narrative world is principally divided into four streams:

(a) Folk tales in their pure form, of which "Lachhminiya Kaniya" and "Hanuman Nam Smaranke Mahima" are outstanding examples.

(b) Fresh interpretations of mythological narratives: "Yajna-Sita," "Chhaunri-Chhaunra Sudyumna," "Lakshmi-Bali," "Tap Aa Satsang" and "Hridaybasi Ishwar."

(c) Didactic tales: "Shiksha Aa Diksha" and "Number."

(d) Stories and folk narratives: "Kutta-Bilai-Mus" and "Gonubabu Gharepar."

(e) Narrative poetry: "Dam" (an extended verse narrative, *Sakshi*).

Two elements lie at the heart of all his tales: the vitality of spoken Maithili and the language's sociocultural reality. Together they give his narratives a distinctive geographical and cultural identity.

Reviews of the Tales

1. "Hanuman Nam Smaranke Mahima" (The Glory of Remembering Hanuman's Name)

1(a) Plot: The nine planetary deities, the *Navagraha*, are imprisoned in Ravana's Lanka, powerless and miserable. While setting Lanka ablaze, Hanuman sees them, asks about their plight, breaks their bonds and sets them free. The Navagraha invite Hanuman to seek a boon, but he replies, "Lord Rama is with me; I have no need to ask for any boon." The Navagraha then make a promise of their own: those who recite Hanuman's name will suffer no harm at their hands.

1(b) Linguistic analysis: This is an excellent specimen of Maithili. Forms such as "rahae," "hai," "ai," "aela," "hunkasabke" and "okarasabke" are natural Maithili forms, not substantially different from the language of Darbhanga and Mithila in India.

"As he went about setting fires here and there in Lanka, Hanuman caught sight of the nine planetary deities, stripped of their strength and power, as though dead and withered."

"Agi-laggi," "agarahi-pasahi" and "muil-vilai" are living evidence of Maithili expression. The paired compound "muil-vilai" (dead and withered) exemplifies the language's grammatical riches.

1(c) Rasa: The devotional sentiment predominates, but it is not devotion alone. The pathos of the Navagraha's misery and the heroic sentiment of Hanuman's bravery in breaking Ravana's bonds create a composite experience of rasa. According to Ānandavardhana's theory of *dhvani*, the principal suggestion is that "divine grace comes not through asking, but through surrendering oneself." This suggested meaning lies beyond the literal sense.

1(d) Vakrokti: Viewed through Kuntaka's concept of oblique expression, the tale's most striking statement is "With him beside me, why should I ask you for any boon?" Conventionally, the devotee requests a boon and the deity grants it. Here Hanuman reverses the logic of devotion: "Asking for a boon is a weakness in devotion." This reversal gives an ordinary tale philosophical elevation.

1(e) A Navya-Nyāya perspective: According to Gangesha's account of verbal testimony (*śabda-pramāṇa*, or the statement of a trustworthy authority), the Navagraha's promise that "those who chant Hanuman's name will suffer no harm" constitutes reliable testimony. In Navya-Nyāya such testimony has evidentiary value because its speakers, the Navagraha, are trustworthy. Through a folk tale Kapari makes this scholastic argument accessible.

1(f) The Videha framework: The tradition of Hanuman stories in Maithili literature is very old. Kapari, however, places this narrative in a new geographical and cultural location. When a Maithili storyteller from Janakpurdham, Nepal, recounts a tale of Rama, Ravana and Hanuman, its folk voice and perspective are distinctly his own.

2. "Lachhminiya Kaniya": Parmeshwar Kapari's Finest Folk Tale

2(a) Plot: An elderly couple live in a village. Their daughter-in-law is slight of build and ordinary to look at, yet notably resourceful and clever in household work and judgement. One night a jackal calls out, and the daughter-in-law understands its language. It says that a corpse floating in the river has a pair of precious rubies in its thigh. The young woman courageously retrieves the jewels, gives the corpse to the jackal and returns home. Her mother-in-law misunderstands, imagining that she has been eating a corpse. A commotion follows and the daughter-in-law is sent to her parental home. Along the road a crow speaks; she understands the crow's language too. It tells her that feeding milk to a snake that day will lead the snake to show her diamonds and pearls. She explains this to her father-in-law, who believes her. They feed the snake milk and puffed grain, and obtain jewels. The household becomes prosperous, and mother-in-law and daughter-in-law begin living together happily.

2(b) Structural analysis of the folk tale: According to Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928), folk tales possess a definite underlying structure. "Lachhminiya Kaniya" follows that structure closely:

(i) Initial lack: poverty and the humiliation of the daughter-in-law.

(ii) Donor: the jackal and the crow, who impart knowledge to the daughter-in-law.

(iii) Helper function: knowledge of animal speech, the daughter-in-law's special power.

(iv) Test or challenge: the courage required to approach the river at night.

(v) Final victory: the jewels and the reconciliation of the family.

One distinctive feature of the Maithili–Mithila tradition is the addition of the snake-and-milk episode at the end. This is the Maithili folk tale's own creative supplement.

2(c) Extraordinary lexical richness: The most important feature of "Lachhminiya Kaniya" is the wealth of words drawn from the spoken folk language. The following clusters are priceless elements of Maithili's living vocabulary:

"labakaniya," "harharahi khatbanari," "chhotkhutiya bhutiya," "chhagunaae," "dhatpatae," "gundhunaae," "paniaae," "lobhaae," "jhisi-bunnibala," "bikaral rait," "huan-huan," "jumus banhik," "habakka mari," "lattopato," "hathi-bardam," "dhukka-pharki," "dhipal aig-baul," "chhabakal dabakal," "pithiya-thok dhamakka," "nangatiniya

rakamsani," "odhabadhak," "lohchhi jhantiyak," "pachhamuriya kandariya," and "hapais-lapaikak."

These words remain alive in Maithili folk speech. Kapari gathers and safeguards them, giving them literary standing; therein lies his greatest contribution.

2(d) The daughter-in-law's character: The young woman looks ordinary, "labakaniya, chhotkhutiya bhutiya," but possesses the rare power of understanding animal speech. Folk tradition calls this accomplishment *pashu-siddhi* and it makes her extraordinary. She goes to the river alone at night—courage. She removes jewels from a corpse —resourcefulness. She withstands her mother-in-law's anger—patience. She understands the crow and convinces her father-in-law—intelligence. She becomes the emblem of Mithila's "Lachhminiya": a brave, intelligent woman who brings prosperity, an ideal of female agency.

2(e) The union of devotional and pathetic sentiments: The middle of the tale blends the mother-in-law's anger (*raudra rasa*) with the daughter-in-law's helplessness (*karuṇa rasa*). At the end, however, the emotional movement resolves into *śānta rasa*: "After that, mother-in-law and daughter-in-law, and everyone in the household, lived together in mutual understanding, happiness and delight." This traditional happy ending of a Maithili folk tale upholds an ideal of domestic life.

2(f) Comparative perspective: "Lachhminiya Kaniya" belongs to the Maithili tradition of the "Sunari-Bahuriya" tale. In many stories from that tradition, however, the daughter-in-law is merely a passive recipient of magic. Here she takes risks and uses her intelligence. The distinction matters: Kapari makes the daughter-in-law an *agent*, not merely a *patient* upon whom events act.

3. "Yajna-Sita": A Bold Reinterpretation of Mythological Narrative

3(a) Plot: Whenever King Rama performs a sacrifice, an image of Sita fashioned from gold is made. A group of these sacrificial Sitas gathers in Rama's residence. They feel aggrieved and neglected. One day they all approach Rama and demand recognition. Rama cites his vow of monogamy: "I have taken the hand in marriage of Sita, daughter of Janaka, ruler of Mithila." The sacrificial Sitas ask, "Why were we needed to help with the sacrifice but not accepted in life?" At last Rama offers a solution: in his incarnation as Krishna in the Dvapara age, they will become *gopīs*. "All those sacrificial Sitas became gopīs in Braj."

3(b) Literary courage: This is one of Kapari's boldest compositions. Rama and Sita are sacred figures in Maithili folk tradition, and to question their relationship is unusual. Kapari nevertheless reconsiders it from Mithila's Sita-centred standpoint: Sita is Janaka's daughter, a daughter of Mithila.

"While the sacrifice is being performed, we are absolutely indispensable! / Without us it is incomplete! / Does not the officiant conduct the sacrifice together with us?"

This argument is unassailable from a scriptural standpoint. The wife, the husband's other half, is indispensable to the sacrifice under Vedic prescription. By placing this scriptural reasoning in the mouths of the sacrificial Sitas, Kapari compels Rama to answer them.

3(c) Folk feminism: The work is an excellent example of a discourse on women's rights in Maithili folk literature. The sacrificial Sita is not merely a "helpless woman": she reasons, makes demands and understands her rights. "And yet you call yourself the ideal Maryada Purushottam?" This question opens a new chapter in the Maithili literature of Nepal.

3(d) Analysis of dhvani: At the literal level, the composition tells the tale of the sacrificial Sitas. At the level of suggestion, however, Kapari communicates a profound message: "A society that makes use of women's labour but denies them rights is out of balance." From Ānandavardhana's standpoint, that *dhvani* is the soul of the composition.

3(e) Within the tradition of mythological reinterpretation: The Maithili poet Vidyapati (distinct from the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati) considered mythological narratives afresh in *Bhuparikrama* and *Purushapariksha*. Kapari carries that tradition forward with a new social consciousness. This is an important aspect of Videha's parallel history.

4. "Chhaunri-Chhaunra Sudyumna": A Mythological Tale of Gender Transformation

4(a) Plot: King Vaivasvata Manu and Queen Shraddha desire a son. The queen arranges a rite for begetting a boy but says, "If there is to be a child, let it be a daughter." As a result a girl, Ila, is born. At five or seven years of age, the girl displays masculine conduct. An investigation reveals that the priest's incantation at the sacrifice was intended to produce a son; the queen's wish caused a daughter to be born, but masculine qualities remained. Through the power of austerity, Vasishtha transforms the girl into a boy, Sudyumna. Sudyumna enters a forest where Shiva and Parvati enjoy their play, and becomes a woman. The sage Budha falls in love with this woman, and their son Pururavas is born. Vasishtha then arranges a recitation of the *Devi Bhagavata*, making Sudyumna permanently male. A coronation follows.

4(b) Gender discourse: The story is based on the *Śrīmad Devī Bhāgavata Mahāpurāṇa* (Chapter 3). Kapari retells it in the language of Maithili folk speech. It raises the question of gender transformation or gender fluidity, a subject linked with contemporary debates about gender. The queen's wish, "If a child is born, let it be a daughter," reverses society's preference for sons.

4(c) The Vitality of Language

"When Ila, their daughter, had reached the age of four or five, her whole bearing and manner began to seem masculine! She was a girl, yet she spoke and did many things like a boy."

"Bagay-bani" and "chhara jika" are indigenous Maithili expressions. The first means bearing and demeanour; the second means "like a boy." These terms may not be found in standard dictionaries of Maithili.

4(d) A Navya-Nyāya perspective: In terms of Gangesha's theory of *vyāpti*, the tale contains a chain of reasoning: (a) listening to the *Devi Bhagavata* (the reason or *hetu*) leads to (b) Sudyumna's permanent male form (the proposition to be proved, or *sādhya*). Kapari, however, does not treat this concomitance as ultimate truth: Pururavas, Sudyumna's son, is evidence of Sudyumna's earlier motherhood. This is a dramatic application of Navya-Nyāya's method of challenging a proposed *vyāpti*.

5. "Hridaybasi Ishwar" (God Who Dwells in the Heart)

5(a) Plot: At the beginning of creation, God gives human beings special intelligence and knowledge. But humans start searching for God over every small and large problem. Troubled by this, God hides in forests, mountains, caves and ravines, but people find him there too. Finally God hides where humans will not think of looking: within their own hearts.

5(b) Vedānta and folk tradition: A union of three traditions. The germ of the story belongs to three traditions: (a) Vedānta—"Tat tvam asi": Brahman resides within oneself; (b) the Maithili folk tale, in which the search for God ends in the heart; and (c) Kapari's transformation of this metaphysical insight into humorous narrative rather than dry philosophy. The portrayal of stubborn, demanding people relentlessly looking for God is a fine example of comic rasa.

5(c) Play with Language

"However far God went to hide himself in a secluded corner, those insistent, headstrong, self-interested people searched him out there as well."

"Aurh kat" (a secluded corner), "ghaihar garju" (excessively insistent) and "hehar-thethar" (obstinate and stubborn) testify to the vitality of Maithili. The expressive sounds "ghaihar" and "hehar" make their meanings almost audible.

5(d) Humour and philosophy: God's irritation is an anthropomorphic image typical of folk narrative. Kapari, however, turns it into a philosophical proposition: where God is most readily available—in the heart—humankind never searches. This irony, or *vakrokti*, raises the folk tale to the level of philosophy.

6. "Lakshmi-Bali Khissa": The Raksha Bandhan Episode

6(a) Plot: Vishnu serves as a gatekeeper at King Bali's door because he is bound by a promise. Lakshmi waits anxiously. Narada explains what happened in the Vamana–Bali episode. Lakshmi disguises herself, visits King Bali and ties a protective thread on his wrist. Bali offers her a gift. She asks, "Give me that gatekeeper." Bali grants the request. From then on, Raksha Bandhan becomes the festival of brothers and sisters.

6(b) A fusion of folk narrative and Purāṇic mythology: The story draws upon the *Vishnu Purana* and Bhagavata traditions. Kapari, however, fills it with the vitality of everyday Maithili: "ahar takay, pahar takay," "batjohime ankh khiya," "talbal-talbal ladh-dular," "halasal lahalot"—idiomatic expressions that animate the tale.

"Bali greatly liked Lakshmi's bearing and demeanour. His curiosity grew, and advancing towards her with affectionate eagerness, he asked, 'Well then, dear child, who are you?'"

"Hapasi-lapakik," an idiom meaning to rush forward with affection, is exactly right. Lakshmi's assumed role as a sister is a natural expression of love.

6(c) Women's Agency and Power

Lakshmi is not passive in this tale. She devises her own plan, changes her appearance, negotiates with Bali and secures Vishnu's release. The goddess of wealth is capable of freeing her own husband: this is a powerful narrative of female agency.

7. "Tap Aa Satsang" (Austerity and Good Company)

7(a) Plot: Vishvamitra and Vasishtha quarrel over whether austerity or the company of the wise is superior. Neither Brahma nor Vishnu wishes to become entangled in the argument. At last Sheshanaga offers a test: lifting the burden of the earth. Vishvamitra applies all the power of his austerities but cannot lift it. Vasishtha offers "the merit earned from one day in good company," and the earth rises into the air. Austerity loses; *satsang* wins.

7(b) The philosophical fable: This is a philosophical tale of argument in which a difficult question is resolved in narrative form. "Austerity" and "good company" stand for the relation between individual discipline and a social-spiritual community.

Kapari's humorous outlook is also alive: "Very good, an excellent idea! Lord Shesha told both of them to their faces." The idiom "soharde ange" (directly to someone's face) humorously casts Shesha in the role of a judge.

7(c) The Use of Folk Language

"Hearing this, Vishvamitra felt the sting of envy and, flaring up in anger, exclaimed, 'What! How can I possibly fail to lift such a little weight!'"

"Ikh-bikh lagab" (to burn with envy) and "pinakale-phanaki" (to flare up with anger) are two priceless Maithili idioms.

8. Didactic Tales: "Shiksha Aa Diksha" and "Number"

8(a) "Shiksha Aa Diksha" (Education and Initiation)

In the traditional *gurukula*, a teacher strikes a prince without apparent reason before sending him away, in public view. The next day he explains why: "So that you may experience injustice. When you become king and dispense justice, you will know the pain of those who have suffered wrong."

The didactic narrative is close to India's tradition of moral tales, yet its method of "experiential learning" also corresponds to the principles of modern pedagogy. "Thereupon everyone's inner eyes were opened": that sentence is the philosophical essence of the story.

8(b) "Number"

At night a wealthy merchant loses his way and enters a temple. He gives money to a distressed person and also hands him his own card bearing a number. The person says, "I know your number." Astonished, the merchant asks what he means. "God's number," the man replies, "the one who sent you to me."

This is an excellent didactic tale with a twist ending. It occupies barely a page but carries a profound philosophical message. This portrayal of faith in God is among the finest examples of the Maithili moral tale.

9. "Kutta-Bilai-Mus" (Dog, Cat and Mouse)

9(a) Plot: Dog, Cat and Mouse are three friends. Dog leaves on a pilgrimage and entrusts all his papers to Cat, who gives them to Mouse for safekeeping. Mouse chews them up and destroys them while using them for food and bedding. When Dog returns, the papers are gone. Cat attempts to kill Mouse. Mouse flees, unable to understand why everyone is pursuing him. "Ever since then, dogs chase cats, and cats chase mice, whenever they see one another."

9(b) The character of an origin tale: This is an aetiological tale, one that explains the supposed origin of a familiar occurrence. It offers an amusing folk answer to the question of why dogs chase cats and cats chase mice. This narrative type is found in folk traditions across the world; Rudyard Kipling's *Just So Stories* provides a Western parallel.

9(c) The problem of justice: The line "The mouse could not understand why everybody was chasing him" is profound. He ate and used the papers as bedding because they served his needs, but his conduct harmed the others. The narrative concerns the consequences of an unwitting wrong. From the perspective of Navya-Nyāya, the mouse's absence of knowledge does not in itself make his action morally criminal.

10. "Gonubabu Gharepar" (Gonu Babu at Home)

10(a) Plot: Gonu Jha is "the craftiest of the crafty, exceptionally nimble and clever." He returns to his village after a long absence. Everyone asks, "Where had you gone?" He replies, "You could say, right here in the village." They are astonished. The real explanation is that in the months of Ashvin and Kartik people come seeking favours and provisions. To avoid them, Gonu had left home and the village. Even on his return he says, "You could say Gonu Babu was at home."

10(b) Place in the Gonu Jha tradition: Gonu Jha is a distinctive Maithili folk hero—cunning, satirical and keenly aware of his own interests. His counterparts in other traditions include Nasreddin Hodja (Turkish), Akaltam (Hebrew) and Birbal (Hindi). Kapari keeps this tradition alive.

The statement "You could say Gonu Babu was at home" has several levels of meaning: (a) literal—"I was here in the village"; (b) satirical—"I shall not tell you where I went"; (c) implied—"I fled the village to avoid people coming to ask for things." These three levels exemplify Kuntaka's *vakrokti*.

10(c) Social satire: "In these months even the storeroom of the grandest house ends up empty." This precisely depicts the financial squeeze of Ashvin and Kartik. Gonu Jha's cleverness is a strategy for living, funny yet grounded in reality. It reflects the economic cycle of rural Maithil society.

Overall Critical Evaluation

12(a) Distinctive Features of Kapari as a Storyteller

Preservation of Maithili in Its Authentic Form

Kapari's most distinctive contribution is to give literary dignity to the authentic Maithili of an alternative tradition. Words such as "labakaniya," "harharahi," "chhagunaae," "dhatpatae," "hapasi-lapakik," "pachhamuriya," "hathi-bardam," "ghaihar garju" and "hehar-thethar" might never have entered literary writing had Kapari not recorded them.

Reviving the Tradition of Animal Speech

The knowledge of animal language in "Lachhminiya Kaniya" and divine intelligence in "Hanuman Nam Smaranke Mahima" keep alive the ancient *Pañcatantra–Jātaka* tradition of Maithili folk narrative. That tradition had almost disappeared from modern Maithili storytelling.

Counter-Readings of Mythology

In "Yajna-Sita," Kapari questions the Rama–Sita relationship; in "Chhaunri-Sudyumna," he treats gender transformation; and in "Hay Ram!" he interrogates Rama's "maryada," or moral propriety. In these pieces he does not accept mythological narrative with closed eyes. His engagement is critical, and that is the basis of his modernity.

Skilful Use of Humour and Satire

"Gonubabu Gharepar," "Number," "Tap Aa Satsang" and "Hridaybasi Ishwar" all contain humour and satire. But the humour goes beyond simple amusement to philosophy and social commentary.

12(b) Limitations

(a) Length: Most tales are very short—roughly the size of a Facebook post—making profound character development difficult.

(b) Repetition: Many subjects recur, a consequence of insufficient editing.

(c) Range of subject matter: Most tales concern religious mythology or folk morality. There are very few stories grounded in contemporary social reality, like "Lachhminiya."

12(c) Place in the History of Maithili Folk Narrative

In the history of Maithili folk tales, Kapari is a rare figure in the Maithili tradition for making rural Maithili the medium of literary storytelling.

From the perspective of Videha parallel history: "What the Canon Left Out." Kapari's stories have been "left out" of mainstream Maithili literary history. A storyteller working in Maithili in Nepal did not find a place in a history centred on the Sahitya Akademi. Through this critical review Videha seeks to correct that injustice.

Dedicated to the writer: Parmeshwar Kapari, a true servant of the soil and water of Mithila.

Gajendra Thakur

Parmeshwar Kapari: A Critical Review of His Verse Compositions

(Including original compositions, translations and quoted verse)

Rasa–Dhvani–Vakrokti • Navya-Nyāya • Videha Parallel History

Introduction: The World of Parmeshwar Kapari's Poetry

Parmeshwar Kapari's collected writings reveal verse at several levels: his own poems; ghazals by other poets quoted in his criticism; children's songs; a translation from the Rigveda; Maithili renderings of Sanskrit verses; and various folk songs and *phakṛās*. These verse compositions fall into the following categories:

(a) Original Maithili dohas and independent short verses.

(b) The Maithili translation of the Rigveda's Nāsadīya Sūkta, "Tattvabodh."

(c) Maithili sense-translations of Sanskrit verses—from the Gītā, the Nāsadīya hymn and the Sītā-stotra.

(d) Children's songs: "Hamar Janakpurdham" and "Sita Avatar."

(e) Song-*phakṛās* from "Reṅ-Reṅ."

(f) A Hindi ghazal by Dhirendra Premarshi, together with Kapari's review.

(g) Maithili ghazals by Dr Rajendra Vimal, together with Kapari's detailed criticism.

(h) The narrative poem "Dam."

1. "Tattvabodh": A Maithili Translation of the Rigveda's Nāsadīya Sūkta

This is the most ambitious verse composition in the entire collection of materials. Kapari presents a Maithili translation, based on the Radhakrishnan–Moore volume, of the 129th hymn of the Rigveda's tenth maṇḍala—the "Nāsadīya Sūkta," which poses some of world literature's earliest philosophical questions about the mystery of creation.

1(a) The Passage in Verse

There was no one then
nor even the lifeless
no air
nor the sky above it /

What was concealed
where?
under whose protection
and was there a deep, immeasurable ocean?

There was as yet no death
nor was there immortal life /

It breathed in the airlessness
apart from it there was nothing here.

In the beginning desire entered it
with this thought
it was the very first seed of creation.

Who knows with certainty?
Who will make it clear?
When was it born
and when was this creation made?

God alone knows this
and perhaps even He does not know!

1(b) An Analysis of the Translator's Craft

The Rigvedic original, "nāsad āsīn no sad āsīt tadānīm" ("neither being nor non-being existed then"), describes the state before creation through negation: "Then there was neither existence nor non-existence." In Kapari's translation it becomes "There was no one then / nor even the lifeless." These short, broken lines are the marks not merely of translation but of re-creation.

In the original Sanskrit, "ānīd avātam svadhayā tad ekam" means that the One breathed, by its own power, without air. Kapari writes, "It breathed in the airlessness." This single line is poetry of the deepest oxymoron in Maithili. Breathing where there is no air: the very contradiction expresses the ineffability of what precedes creation.

1(c) Analysis of Rasa

Of the nine rasas described by Bharata Muni, *adbhuta*, the sentiment of wonder, pervades this poem. "It was the very first seed of creation" is the culmination of this wondrous rasa. Yet the last line—"God alone knows this / and perhaps even He does not know!"—transforms wonder into *karuṇa*: the pathos of not knowing.

1(d) A Navya-Nyāya Perspective

According to the principle of the "limits of the means of knowledge" (*epistemological limits*) associated here with Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, none of the four *pramāṇas*—perception, inference, comparison and verbal testimony—can supply knowledge of the state before creation. "Who

knows with certainty?" Within this question, Navya-Nyāya's limit of cognition is itself suggested through Kapari's translation.

1(e) Analysis of Dhvani

In terms of Ānandavardhana's theory of *dhvani*, the poem has three levels of suggestion: (a) the literal, a description of the physical condition before creation; (b) the figurative, a depiction of human ignorance; and (c) philosophical resonance—"Even God may not know"—which is the deepest suggestion of agnosticism. Philosophical poetry of this order is extremely rare in Maithili literature.

1(f) The Videha Framework

This bold tradition of translating Vedic philosophy is rare in Maithili poetry. After Vidyapati, who built a bridge between Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha, Kapari brings the Rigveda's most mysterious hymn into Maithili and initiates a new tradition. This is a significant chapter in Videha parallel history.

2. Original Dohas and Independent Verses

2(a) A Political Doha

> The bell rang; politics stirred to life.
> See how many parties died while still alive.

This doha is the finest poetic expression of Kapari's political satire. Two lines contain an entire satirical portrait.

"The bell rang"—the election bell. "Politics stirred to life"—renewed enthusiasm. "Died while still alive"—the moral death of political parties. The capacity of the doha lies precisely in gathering these three successive movements into only two lines.

Kuntaka's *vakrokti* appears in "died while still alive": death in the midst of life. That paradox compresses the collapse of political morality into a single image. In Nepal's political reality, a party does not "die while alive" simply because it loses an election, but because its soul has died. This is a distinguished example of the modern Maithili doha.

2(b) An Aphoristic Verse Based on a Proverb

A whole village full of healers—whose guidance shall we follow? This two-line, proverb-based verse was spoken in the context of Martyrs' Day. "A whole village full of healers" means everyone in the village considers himself an expert; "whose guidance shall we follow?" asks where direction is to be found.

Kapari uses this proverb in discussing political movements. Nepal has innumerable martyrs and leaders of "movements," but an absence of genuine leadership. This metaphorical application is an instance of poetic-political argument.

Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* supplies the category of *hāsya-rasa*, the comic sentiment; but here the laughter is on the surface and the pathos lies within. This combination produces the rasa of "A whole village full of healers."

2(c) A Short Verse on the Mother

> There is no mother like a mother.
> There is no one like a mother.

In only six or seven words, the word *māy* ("mother") acquires limitless significance. This is poetry of the greatest brevity and the greatest emotional concentration. "There is no mother like a mother" expresses absolute uniqueness: no one can be compared with one's mother.

At the basis of *karuṇa-rasa* lies the height of tender parental love, *vātsalya*. What is described here as Bharata Muni's *vātsalya* as an enduring emotion, subsumed within *karuṇa* in Indian aesthetics, is condensed into these two lines. The verse was spoken on Mother's Day, but its truth transcends the occasion.

2(d) A Birthday Verse

> Today, on the day of breaking the Chhath fast, on Diwāti (Lakshmi Puja), is Mother's birthday.
> On the day of breaking the Chhath fast, of Chhathi Parameshwari, is Father's birthday.
> The names of both accord with their birthdays: Mother is Lakshmi because hers falls on Lakshmi Puja, and Father is Parmeshwar because his falls on the Chhath fast-breaking day.

A son, Kumar Bhaskar, offers his parents a birthday tribute. This composition is not by Kapari but by his son. The occasion involves a striking poetic coincidence: Lakshmi (the mother) and Parmeshwar (the father), their names corresponding to the festivals—her birth on Lakshmi Puja, his on the day of breaking the Chhath fast. Such poetry of coincidence has its own distinctive place in Maithili tradition.

3. Children's Songs: "Hamar Janakpurdham" (from *Hamar Maithili Pothi*, Class Three) and "Sita Avatar" (by Bhuvaneshwar Prasad "Adhyapak," from *Maithili Bal Ramayan*)

3(a) "Hamar Janakpurdham" ("Our Janakpur Dham")

The home of Lava and Kusha's maternal uncle—
that is our Janakpur Dham.
Sita, through her ideals, made
this land of Mithila sacred in name.
This capital of Janaka of Videha
gave birth to many a sage.
The Maithili language is as sweet as honey;
those who speak it are proud Maithils.

This children's song is included in *Hamar Maithili Pothi*, Class Three. Kapari quotes it; the quotation itself bears witness to his concern for children's literature.

"The home of Lava and Kusha's maternal uncle": the poetic convention of calling Janakpur the maternal home of Lava and Kusha is an old one in Maithili. The song employs it naturally.

"The Maithili language is as sweet as honey": this simile is distinctive. The sweetness of sound is compared with the sweetness of food. This transposition across the senses is *synaesthesia*.

Rasa: *vīra-rasa*, the heroic sentiment. "Proud Maithils" awakens self-respect and plants the seed of courage in children's minds.

3(b) "Sita Avatar" ("The Incarnation of Sita"), by Bhuvaneshwar Prasad "Adhyapak," from *Maithili Bal Ramayan*

How did Sita take birth?
Listen: the tale is long.
When the night-roaming demons unleashed disorder,
all religious duties fell into ruin.

No rain fell upon Mithila;
then Janaka took the plough in his own hands.
The moment he began to till the earth,
she appeared from the soil.

A voice resounded through the sky—
the World-Mother had taken birth.
As the demons multiplied upon the earth,
she came to remove the world's burden.
Mother Earth bestowed on King Janaka a new gift;
the world could find release from pain, grief and sorrow.

Kapari quotes this children's song, and the choice is apt. "Sita Avatar" is an important song from the Maithili children's Ramayana, recounting, in a simple, accessible rhythm, the mythological account of Sita's birth associated with Ravana's vessel of blood.

"The moment he began to till the earth / she appeared from the soil": these are the finest two lines of the song. The distinctive Maithili expression *dhatibhūmi* means "appearing from the ground." Rhythm, rhyme and feeling are all held in balance.

The final quatrain—"A voice resounded through the sky"—acquires grandeur through its longer lines. Such rhythmic rise and fall keeps the children's song from becoming monotonous.

4. The Song-*Phakṛā* from "Reṅ-Reṅ"

The swollen-throated boaster, the chameleon-like fellow,
the leaping frog, the mouse as palanquin bearer—
the wedding procession is dressed and ready!

The one who makes the world laugh, who knocks off his father's turban,
the unruly little rat goes to wed—
and the procession sets off to the cat's house!

4(a) The Nature of the *Phakṛā*

This is a song-*phakṛā* from the play "Reṅ-Reṅ." The Maithili *phakṛā* tradition is a distinctive type of folk song in which animal characters satirise human society.

4(b) An Analysis of Symbols

"Swollen-throated boaster" suggests the politician's self-praise. "Chameleon-like fellow" is the politician who changes colours. "Leaping frog" denotes an opportunist. "The mouse as palanquin bearer"—a procession of mice heading to a cat's house—is traditional Maithili burlesque.

"One who knocks off his father's turban" is someone who destroys his father's honour. "The unruly little rat goes to wed" evokes a disorderly marriage bond. "The procession sets off to the cat's house": the wedding party arriving at the cat's door is the height of comic rasa.

4(c) Connections with Folk-Theatre Traditions

In Maithili folk theatre there is a *naṭuā* tradition of wearing animal masks to satirise society, and the roots of this *phakṛā* are connected with it. Kapari revives that old tradition in the setting of contemporary political theatre.

5. Dhirendra Premarshi's Hindi Ghazal, with Kapari's Readerly Review

5(a) The Text of the Ghazal

Be patient, my friend
put off your needs, my friend.
Happiness walks beside sorrow;
move with the times, my friend.

Whatever God has given you,
preserve it, my friend.
What use is resentment?
Drive it from your mind, my friend.

In losing yourself, examine
the self within yourself, my friend.
Plunge into love and become
wealthy beyond measure, my friend.

If you would become a "Premarshi,"
keep your heart aflame, my friend.

5(b) Kapari's Critical Perspective: A Piece of Poetic Prose in Its Own Right

The "reader's perplexity" Kapari recorded after reading this ghazal is itself a piece of poetic prose. His first reaction was: "The moment I stepped into the third line, my disillusionment soured my mind—good heavens, this is a Hindi ghazal!" That is a natural response from someone devoted to Maithili.

But Kapari then acknowledges his own narrowness and looks at the ghazal objectively: "When we examine and grasp the totality of the linguistic and literary grace of his composition, we must concede that, through this poem, his command of language and the structure of the ghazal are distinctive and pleasing." This self-correction demonstrates Kapari's honesty as a critic.

5(c) A Poetic Analysis of the Ghazal

"Happiness walks beside sorrow": this couplet is connected with the Sufi concept of *fanā*, the dissolution of the self. Happiness and grief are opposites, yet companions. Such paradoxical beauty belongs to the essential spirit of the Urdu ghazal.

"In losing yourself, examine / the self within yourself": seeking *khudī* (the self) within *bekhudī* (self-loss) is the Sufi method of self-realisation. It is appropriate for Kapari to place Premarshi within the tradition of Mirabai, Kabir and Rahim.

Kapari's comparative observation—"In him one sees a great deal of the consciousness of an age and the purity of mind associated with Mirabai, Tulsidas and Surdas"—is an outstanding example of Maithili criticism.

6. Dr Rajendra Vimal's Maithili Ghazals: Kapari's Detailed Review

6(a) Ghazal 1: A Call to Revolution

Link arm with arm, raise your voice with force.
He has stolen our bread; tear open his belly.

He makes us deaf and goes on biting; do not worship him.
Seize him by the neck; take a sword in your hand.

The one who drank my blood—I shall spill his blood.
Let flames spread through every drop of our own blood.

To slay Ravana is righteousness; the Lanka of sin will burn.
Beat the drums and plant the banner of dharma.

I shall go on chanting amid the tumult of words, Vimal.
Arrange and adorn the Diwali of awakened consciousness.

Critical Review

Kapari describes this ghazal as "very aggressive and explosive," and the description is accurate. "Seize him by the neck; take a sword in your hand" is the culmination of *raudra-rasa*, the furious sentiment. Bharata Muni identifies anger as the enduring emotion of *raudra*, and it is powerfully present in this couplet.

"He has stolen our bread" opens a discussion of exploitation. "Tear open his belly" expresses metaphorical revenge: it is not a literal call to violence but a poetic demand for justice. In terms of *vakrokti*, "plant the banner of dharma" turns resistance into a righteous war; that is its oblique symbolic system.

6(b) Ghazal 2: "Mar Sar Dogalake" ("Strike Down the Two-Faced Scoundrels"): A Satirical Ghazal

Bang, bang, the shots ring out: strike down the two-faced scoundrels.
Here is the command being given: strike down the two-faced scoundrels.

They will not spare your fields, homes, daughters or daughters-in-law.
They come under cover: strike down the two-faced scoundrels.

Generation after generation, they have only slit your throats.
Here is a gang of throat-cutters: strike down the two-faced scoundrels.

In this ghazal, "strike down the two-faced scoundrels" is the same *radīf*, or refrain, in all five units; this technique of repetition intensifies *raudra-rasa*. "Fields, homes, daughters and daughters-in-law" means everything in life: exploitation that devours all. *Gheṅṭ-kaṭṭā ṭolī*, a gang of throat-

cutters, is a distinctive Maithili term of abuse. Its use in poetry is an audacious linguistic experiment.

6(c) Ghazal 3: "Chhai Kon Lokak Basti" ("Whose Settlement Is This?")

Whose settlement is this? Everyone here lies wounded.
Every head is under lock, and every tongue has been cut out.

People move here hanging together on a gallows.
What city is this, where people hang themselves of their own will?

The constitution changes daily, like a sex worker's new skirt.
My mother's garment, even today, is still torn.

This is Vimal's finest ghazal. "A settlement where everyone lies wounded" makes a remarkable opening couplet, or *matla*. "Heads under lock, tongues cut out" is a metaphor for intellectual and verbal enslavement. "People moving in groups, hanging from the gallows" introduces an image of crucifixion that is new to modern Maithili ghazal writing.

"The constitution changes daily, like a sex worker's new skirt": the comparison between the constitution and a sex worker is profoundly controversial, but poetically forceful. "My mother's garment is still torn" becomes a personal and universal image of poverty, and it is this that gives Vimal his stature.

6(d) Ghazal 4: "Takhane Diwali Thik" ("Only Then Is It Diwali")

When the whole creation shines, only then is it Diwali.
When the lamp of consciousness burns, only then is it Diwali.

Make the old and worn-out things objects of open ridicule.
When a new lamp burns every moment, only then is it Diwali.

Architects of darkness, beware! Beware!
When rocket-bombs fly into battle, only then is it Diwali.

In this ghazal, "only then is it Diwali" is the *radīf*: each couplet places a new condition upon the celebration of Diwali. "The lamp of consciousness" signifies intellectual awakening. *Hukkālōlī*, a folk-language word for open mockery, is rare in a ghazal; its presence brings the vernacular into contact with the Urdu ghazal tradition.

"When rocket-bombs fly into battle, only then is it Diwali": the image of exploding bombs within Diwali's festival of joy is the most oblique expression in the work. Warning the "architects of darkness" is a poetic appeal to revolutionary consciousness.

6(e) Ghazal 5: "Inkilab Gaganme" ("Revolution in the Sky")

Who writes "revolution" and hangs it across the sky?
Who colours earth and heaven with blood?

Who has murdered my poetry of moons and stars?
Who searches for a book of hatred in life?
Rather than starve, people choose to die by bullets.
Knowing this truth, they choose death itself.

"Who writes 'revolution' and hangs it across the sky?" is an opening couplet to remember in the history of Maithili ghazals. "Who colours earth and heaven with blood?" gives an image of sky and earth dyed in blood: a high point of revolutionary poetry.

"The murder of poetry" personifies poetry as a living creature and levels an accusation of its killing—a rare personification in modern Maithili verse. "Rather than starve, people choose to die by bullets" is brutal realism: it speaks of the tragedy of poverty without embellishment. It is a great poetic utterance.

What Parmeshwar Kapari calls a ghazal collection—Rajendra Vimal's *Suryastas Se Pahine* ("Before Sunset")—is in fact a song collection. A ghazal is a distinct literary form, just like the doha, kuṇḍaliyā and rolā; neither Rajendra Vimal nor Dhirendra Premarshi has mastered it. Now consider this so-called children's ghazal from Rajendra Vimal's collection:

Come, sir!
Have some dates!
You are the master;
I am the labourer.
The liquor of power
is smashed to pieces.
You are my servant,
yet I am kept at a distance.
You deceive me
and glare at me.
For five whole years
you whisper into my ears.
Now you come again;
I will seize you and thrash you.
The poor person's heart
will never find fulfilment.
In a honking car,
go on your tour.
The ballot box
will leave you with a hole.
Come, O politician!
I shall certainly come.

Then I shall charge straight at you
with a blow from a stick.
Come, O Crow
Come, O crow, come—come—come!
Fly here, fly here; run here, run here!
Come, little bird, come flying here!
Dance for my little child and let us see.
Come, O parrot, come—come—come!
Come, O myna, come—come—come!
Parrot and myna, fly, fly here!
Peck the mango creeper and bring its fruit down.
The myna came, all grey-feathered.
The parrot came, all green.
It knocked down a dark jamun fruit.
The child spread out a little cloth bag.
My Little Granddaughter
This little granddaughter of mine
is a light of joy and happiness.
She will eat parathas and bread,
and will find no fault with anyone.
Though very small to look at,
she speaks with playful boldness.
Quick to play, quick to cry;
when she laughs, she is pearls and diamonds.
She plays digital games and with toys,
with the little pieces called "touch" and "click."

This could be a good children's song, but it is not a children's ghazal.

7. Maithili Sense-Translations of Sanskrit Verses

7(a) A Verse from the Gītā: "Pitāham Asya Jagato" (Composition No. 86)

Original Sanskrit: "पिता हमस्य जगतो माता धाता पितामहः। वेद्यं पवित्र ओंकार ऋक्सामयजुरेव ॐ।" — "I am the father of this universe, its mother, sustainer and grandsire; I am what is to be known, the holy syllable Om, and the Ṛg, Sāma and Yajur Vedas."

Maithili sense-translation: "I alone am the sustainer of the entire universe —that is, the one who bears and nourishes it and gives the fruits of all actions—and its father, mother and grandfather; I also am the sacred Om that must be known, and the Rigveda, Samaveda and Yajurveda!"

Kapari's method of translation: Sanskrit brevity, in which one verse embraces a universal truth, is expanded and explained in Maithili. "The one who bears and nourishes"—his rendering of *dhātā*—embraces all three meanings attributed to the word: creator, sustainer and giver of the fruits of action.

7(b) A Hymn to Sita: "Tvaṁ Vidyā Paramā Trailokya Jananī"

> Original Sanskrit: "त्वं विद्या परमात्रैलोक्य जननी स्वर्गापवर्ग दायिनी। त्रैलोक्या कर्षणी देवी सीता देवी नमस्तुते।" — "You are supreme knowledge, mother of the three worlds, bestower of heaven and liberation; goddess Sita, who draws the three worlds to you, I bow before you."

Maithili sense-translation: "You are supreme knowledge, the highest Mother of all three worlds. You are the giver of heaven and of other exalted realms. You are the centre of attraction for all three worlds. O Sita, I bow to you!"

"Tvaṁ vidyā"—"You are ... supreme knowledge"—is a direct Sanskrit statement of identity, expanded in Maithili. "Trailokyākarṣiṇī" means "she who draws the three worlds," with the sense of magnetic power. Kapari makes this difficult expression accessible through the simple Maithili phrase "centre of attraction."

7(c) Nārada's Words: A Sense-Translation of a Sanskrit Verse

> Original Sanskrit: "धर्माधर्म विवेकेन वेदमार्गानुसारिणी। सर्वलोकहितासक्ताः साधवः परिकीर्तिताः" — Nārada, 16 (29–31). English: "Those who discriminate between right and wrong, follow the Vedic path and devote themselves to the welfare of all beings are called virtuous persons."

Maithili sense-translation: "A person who distinguishes between dharma and adharma and follows the path taught by the Vedas is called a *sādhu*."

This rendering clarifies Kapari's translation principle: he does not translate word for word. He does not immediately expand "sarvalokahitāsaktāḥ," "devoted to the welfare of all people," because his purpose is to make the meaning of the term *sādhu* clear to Maithili readers, and that purpose has been fulfilled.

7(d) The Gaṅgāsāgara Hymn (Purāṇa)

> Original Sanskrit: "गङ्गाद्याः सरितः सर्वाधिक स्त्रिषु लोकेषु विश्रुता। ता सर्वा अनपायिन्यो गङ्गसागर मण्डलले।" — "The rivers beginning with the Ganga, renowned in the three worlds, are all abiding in the Gaṅgāsāgara region."

Maithili sense-translation: "O Parvati! All the supremely sacred rivers, beginning with the Ganga, renowned throughout the three worlds, dwell perpetually in the Gaṅgāsāgara pond of holy Mithila!"

Kapari quotes this verse to establish the mythological importance of Janakpur's Gaṅgāsāgara pond. He translates "anapāyinyaḥ," which he glosses as "flowing continuously," as "dwelling perpetually." The extension of meaning from "flowing" to "dwelling" is remarkable. The river does not flow; it dwells. This is translation as creation.

8. Suresh Pandit's *Hanuman Chalisa* and "Dam," a Narrative Poem (in *Sakshi*), Presented by Parmeshwar Kapari: A Detailed Analysis of Verse

"Dam" (in *Sakshi*, dedicated to the Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, 2012) is a metrical narrative poem already analysed as a complete story. Here only some significant lines are considered from the standpoint of poetic craftsmanship:

> There was a certain Lambodar Babu, whose belly was always empty.
> He would not lift a finger at work, yet would devour a full plate at once.

"Khattē" ("empty" or "hungry") and "turtē" ("immediately") make an exact rhyme. "He would not even strike a fly in the name of work" is a humorous idiom meaning that he would do no work at all.

> But one day, when he happened to meet someone, the king's order came.
> The preparations for battle were made: "Take the enemy's life!"

"Sājal gel saṅgrām-sāj" ("the battle preparations were arranged") employs alliteration within a single line, repeating the sounds *s* and *j*. It displays an awareness of metre and sonic pattern.

> The very same bread played its trick and took the tiger's life.
> Life ebbs away with ease—thus Lambodar is great.

The closing line, "thus Lambodar is great," confers greatness ironically. Such irony is characteristic of Kapari's humorous and satirical style. "Dam" is a long poem, but its narrative element predominates.

Likewise, writing about Suresh Pandit's *Hanuman Chalisa*, Parmeshwar Kapari says: "Children are mischievous troublemakers, of course; there is no shortage of laughter and joking in their literature either. And Suresh Pandit's *Hanuman Chalisa*, although somewhat older, remains extraordinary and entertaining." Its opening lines are:

> Victory to Hanuman, ocean of knowledge and virtue.
> Mummy laughs; Father cries.

9. Overall Assessment: Kapari's Identity as a Poet

9(a) Strengths

(a) Philosophical depth: His Rigvedic translation is unprecedented in Maithili poetry, giving poetic expression to agnosticism.

(b) A living use of folk-poetic traditions: The *phakṛā* and proverb-based short verse are rooted in Maithili's own cultural soil.

(c) Creative translation: In his Maithili sense-translations of Sanskrit verses, "creative freedom" makes translation a form of re-creation.

(d) Poet-critic: His remarks on Premarshi's free-form Hindi ghazal and Rajendra Vimal's song collection, published as a ghazal collection, are themselves pieces of poetic prose.

(e) Political satirical verse: The doha "The bell rang" is a distinguished example of the modern Maithili doha.

9(b) Limitations

(a) Very little verse is his own: most of the poems are by other poets—Vimal, Premarshi and "Adhyapak"—whose work Kapari reviews.

(b) An absence of substantial original long poems.

(c) Imagery: Kapari's images belong primarily to the folk-narrative tradition; there is little creation of grand modern images.

9(c) His Place in Videha Parallel History

Parmeshwar Kapari is first and foremost a storyteller and playwright, and only secondarily a critic-poet. Nevertheless, his Rigvedic translation ("Tattvabodh"), his political dohas and his *phakṛā* from "Reṅ-Reṅ" constitute noteworthy contributions to the history of Maithili verse. Videha parallel history—"What the Canon Left Out"—accords this poet, critic and translator the recognition he deserves.

Gajendra Thakur

The Literary World of Parmeshwar Kapari: An Extended Review of His Maithili Writings

Introduction: Parmeshwar Kapari and the Range of His Literary Work

Parmeshwar Kapari has produced more than 600 pieces: folk tales, narratives, mythological stories, satire, cultural essays, discussions of language, autobiographical episodes, debates over prizes, political commentaries and theatrical criticism. Together they constitute a vast and many-sided body of writing. From the standpoint of the Videha parallel-history framework, Kapari belongs among the "left-out" Maithili writers whom mainstream literary institutions have largely neglected.

This review undertakes a detailed analysis of each of his literary genres through four approaches: Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti; Western critical theory; Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya epistemology; and the Videha framework of parallel literary history.

Part One: Folk Tales and Folk Narratives

1.1 "Hanuman Nam Smaranke Mahima": This work belongs to the unalloyed tradition of Maithili folk narrative. Kapari recounts the episode involving Ravana, Hanuman and the nine planetary deities in his distinctive *bajaiyā-bol*, the language as people actually speak it. The story is written in conversational Maithili.

Analysis of rasa: *Bhakti-rasa* predominates. Hanuman's compassion, shown in his pity for the nine planetary deities; his heroism in burning Ravana's Lanka; and his devotion as a servant of Rama are beautifully combined. In Ānandavardhana's theory of *dhvani*, Hanuman's statement that he has "no need to ask for a boon" suggests a deeper meaning: divine grace comes not from asking but from surrendering oneself. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, the promise made by the nine deities is *āpta-vākya*, authoritative testimony, as understood through Gaṅgeśa's conception of knowledge acquired from words. An authentic speaker's testimony has validity in Navya-Nyāya, and Kapari renders this philosophical idea accessible through a folk tale. In the Videha framework, this version of the Ramayana tradition places the liberation of the nine planetary deities, rather than Rama and Hanuman alone, at its centre; it expresses Mithila's own perspective. The Hanuman of the people, rather than the Brahmanical mainstream, is an important part of Videha parallel history.

1.2 "Lachhminiya Kaniya": This is among the finest examples of Maithili folk narrative. A linked sequence of an old man, an old woman, their daughter-in-law, a jackal, a crow and a snake tells of an intelligent woman's courage and ingenuity, followed by a reconciliation within the

family. The language is particularly notable: *labakaniyā*, *haṛhaṛahī khaṭbanarī*, *piṭhiyā-ṭhok dhamakkā*, *naṅṭiniyā rakamasanī* and *dhīpal āig-bāul* are treasures of spoken Maithili. Kapari confers literary dignity on such expressions; this is his greatest contribution. As for rasa, the narrative moves successfully from *bhayānaka*, the fearful sentiment when the young wife goes to the river at night, to *hāsya*, the comedy of the old woman's anger and misunderstanding, and finally to *śānta*, the tranquillity of familial reconciliation. The work can be understood through Bharata's threefold structure of *vibhāva*, *anubhāva* and *vyabhicārī-bhāva*. In Kuntaka's terms, "giving the corpse to the jackal to eat" is its most oblique expression. The daughter-in-law is neither an eater of corpses nor a witch; she is a courageous woman free of greed. Yet her mother-in-law sees everything in a distorted light. This reversal is the very substance of *vakrokti*. From a feminist perspective, the daughter-in-law knows no witchcraft and is no witch. She is a brave, competent woman who accomplishes the impossible for her family's well-being. Such an image of women's strength is exceptional in Maithili folk narrative.

1.3 "Yajna-Sita": This is Kapari's most daring, controversial and philosophical work. Golden images of Sita made for a sacrifice come alive and demand acknowledgement from Rama—a rare act of imaginative courage in Maithili writing. In this reinterpretation of myth, Kapari questions Rama's observance of the ideal of taking only one wife. The sacrificial Sita asks, "Then why will you not accept me?" This line inaugurates a new discussion of women's rights in Maithili literature. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, Gaṅgeśa's notion of *vyāpti*, or invariable concomitance, provides the terms of the argument: anyone who participates in the sacrificial rite possesses the rights of a partner or consort. Rama accepts this logical connection but offers an alternative: these Sitas will love Krishna as gopis in the Dvapara age. The philosophical resolution is distinguished. At the level of suggestion, the final sentence—"All those sacrificial Sitas became gopis in Braj"—conveys an important cultural message: every neglected woman ultimately finds liberation.

1.4 "Punyatma Bau Prasang": This is Kapari's most moving autobiographical piece. The account of a son's last moments with his dying father is an instance of emotional intensity in Maithili prose. Its living idiom includes "when I carried the grandson around," *chhaṭpaṭāichhai* and *baṛīkālē*—expressions from Maithili's own vocabulary that touch the heart directly. The father's remark, "Even at the time of death a wave of this sort of restlessness comes over one," expresses affection through extraordinary humour at the brink of death. In the terms attributed here to Abhinavagupta's account of the ultimate resolution of pathos, the father's death brings compassion to its height and teaches the son that "the emotional meaning of the word 'father' cannot be found in a

dictionary!" This sentence deserves a place among the most memorable expressions in Indian writing. In the "Bau" episode, the writer spends his father's final days worrying about his own promotion; acknowledging this human weakness is a mark of realist literature.

1.5 "Limmaviniya Kaviniya": A folk tale of a daughter-in-law who understands the speech of animals—a jackal, a crow and a snake—this is a fine example of the Maithili *bīhani kathā*, or seed-story tradition. Kapari brings about a remarkable conjunction of animal-language studies (*zoolinguistics*) and folk tradition.

Part Two: Mythological and Philosophical Essays

2.1 "Tattvabodh," a Primordial Poem: This is a Maithili translation and re-creation of the Rigveda's Nāsadīya Sūkta (10.129). "There was no one then / nor even the lifeless / no air / nor the sky above it": these lines represent a philosophical high point in Maithili poetry. Within Indian philosophical tradition, the Nāsadīya Sūkta is among the most profound enquiries into the mystery of creation. Kapari makes it available to Maithili readers. "God alone knows this / and perhaps even He does not know!": the last line expresses the essence of agnosticism in Indian thought. From the perspective of Navya-Nyāya, both perception and inference, in Gaṅgeśa's account, are insufficient for knowledge of creation; this is the hymn's suggested meaning. "Who knows with certainty?" acknowledges the limits of the valid means of knowledge.

2.2 "Puranokta Paribhasha" ("Definitions from the Purāṇas"): Kapari explains in Maithili five concepts quoted from the Nārada Smṛti: truth, dharma, non-violence, falsehood and the virtuous person. The incorporation of Nārada's verse—"Those who distinguish dharma from adharma, follow the Vedic path and devote themselves to the welfare of all are called sādhus"—is appropriate. This work demonstrates Kapari's learning: he is not merely a teller of folk tales but also a scholar of classical tradition. Within the Videha framework, this bringing together of śāstric learning and folk tradition is one of his defining characteristics.

2.3 "Chhinnamasta Bhagavatīk Tāntrik Svarūp" ("The Tantric Form of the Goddess Chhinnamasta"): This is Kapari's most scholarly work. His Tantric interpretation of Chhinnamasta through Mithila painting, and the philosophical account it offers of creation, destruction and renewal, are exceptionally profound. "The interaction between light and sound becomes so violent and powerful that the relationship of the created thing with its creator is severed at a stroke": this sentence touches the essence of Indian Tantric philosophy. "Until the umbilical cord between a mother and child is cut, the newborn cannot enter into independent existence": this biological metaphor explains the Tantric symbolism of

Chhinnamasta in a distinctive way. Kapari approaches the Tantric foundations of Mithila painting scientifically and philosophically. Such writing is rare in Maithili literature.

2.4 "Ayurveda and Dhanteras": The account of Brahma's creation of Ayurveda, its three foundational aphorisms, the Ātreya and Dhanvantari traditions, and the churning of the Ocean of Milk demonstrates Kapari's classical knowledge. His threefold classification—"Til Sankranti is a festival of the mind," "Phagua is a festival of the mind," and "Durga Puja is a festival of the soul"—discloses his philosophical perspective.

2.5 "Marriage Rites and Rights": Kapari offers a learned philosophical interpretation of the derivation of the word marriage from *vi* + *ava* + *hāra*, alongside the practices of *kanyādāna*, *pāṇigrahaṇa* and the sacred fire rite. The final sentence—"Ever since income and rights entered marriage, life has become a burden and a whirlpool"—is a satirical comment on modern debate over marriage.

Part Three: Cultural Essays and Commentary on Contemporary Life

3.1 "Bharu Ki Moru?!" ("Indian Rupees or My Rupees?!"): This is a distinguished example of Kapari's cultural-historical essays. Exploring the meanings of *bhāru*, the Indian rupee, and *nēru*, the Nepali rupee, he invites a rethinking of Maithili literary history through Vidyapati's life and Mahendra Malangia's position between Nepal and India. "Vidyapati came to Nepal, established a home and household, dug ponds and wells, completed his life's work and spent the rest of his life and died here—yet is he still 'bhāru'?" This question touches the heart of literary nationalism in Maithili. Kapari favours establishing Nepal's Maithili identity as independent and self-respecting. In the episode concerning Mahendra Malangia's Guinness Book certificate, he raises another important question: if Malangia is called a master of theatre, why should it be wrong to call him "a Maithili playwright of Nepal"? This is a debate over Maithili-Nepali political identity.

3.2 "Maithili Folk Theatre": Kapari's essay on Maithili folk drama is an important document in Maithili theatre history. "Maithili culture possesses its various parts and resources—folk language, folk dance and theatre, songs and ballads": this statement expresses a holistic view of Maithili culture.

In his description of the village of "Parbaha," the derivation from "*parbāh ahā*" ("you care") is interesting and culturally significant. Whoever cares for his language, literature, culture and theatre is a *parbāhā*. This piece of wordplay displays Kapari's linguistic consciousness.

3.3 "Victory to the People's Language, Maithili!": This is a prime example of Kapari's thinking about language. "The language of the Vedas and Purāṇas, of religion, philosophy, art and science—the speech of the gods—became so tightly knotted and inaccessible that it died": this offers a sociological explanation of the decline of Sanskrit. Kapari sees the future of Maithili as a language of the people, not as *babhan-bhāṣā*, the Brahminical standard variety. In this piece he subtly satirises Dr Ramavatar Yadav's "Standard Maithili" movement through the phrase "the stiff, affected Brahmin language." In the Videha parallel-history framework, this is an important argument: Maithili should remain a people's language rather than become the exclusive possession of pundits and scholars.

3.4 "Sitasakhi Gangasagar": Kapari depicts the deterioration of the Gangasagar pond in Janakpur through a mythological fantasy. Gangasagar "takes the form of a wizened old woman" and goes to the Mahakumbh; this symbolic invention is remarkable. There, confronted with the purity of the Ganga's water, she feels ashamed of herself and curses the residents of Janakpur. The satire comments on neglect by the city and its municipal authorities.

Part Four: Satirical Writing

4.1 "Ehanē Janakpur?" ("Is This What Janakpur Has Become?"): This satire concerns the dilapidated roads of Janakpur Sub-Metropolitan City, the breeding of mosquitoes and the indifference of its leaders. Kapari writes: "In Ward No. 16, Pulchowk, of the great sub-metropolitan municipality, back in the year 2051 … during the difficult tenure of Biltu Pajiyar … a mud road was somehow constructed; in the thirty years since then, not a single trailer-load of earth has been laid on it." Such writing is an outstanding example of local journalism. "So, O Janakpur, should we imagine the ghee of a development called Surdas rolling about on a leaf?" The idiom "Surdas's ghee" is a jewel of Maithili satire. The ghee of development, invisible to the blind, becomes a singular satire of negative politics.

4.2 The Series of Political Satires: Kapari's sequences "Hagna-Padna," "Dhoti-Gamchha" and "Bagariya-Sanghatiya" are written as imaginary dialogues. Their satire of Nepali politics—the Gen-Z movement, the decline of Madheshi parties, Balen Shah, Upendra Yadav and K. P. Oli—is pointed and precise.

Linguistic plurality: These dialogues vividly bring out Nepal's multilingual reality. "Look, the point is that his lady from Kathmandu, that madam …": this mixture of languages, or code-mixing, is an important feature of Kapari's literary style.

From the perspective of satirical rasa, Bharata Muni describes six kinds of laughter within *hāsya*: self-directed, directed at others, shared or mutual,

decorous, indecorous and ordinary. Kapari's political satire belongs to the category directed at others; it laughs at the folly and frailty of other people. Its object is not merely entertainment, but social awakening.

4.3 "Janakpur Municipality: A Discussion": Kapari's satire surrounding the release of two books by Rambharos Kapari "Bhramar" exemplifies his fearless critical outlook. "Being yourself the chairperson of the Madhesh Academy, why did you hold the launch at the Maithili Development Fund?" This question strikes directly at the institutional politics of Maithili literature. The piece brings out a significant aspect of Kapari's personality: he speaks forthrightly against institutional corruption and opportunism. "People have lost the courage to speak the truth" (Arun Arya's observation) aptly describes the environment to which Kapari responds.

Part Five: Literary Reviews and the Practice of Criticism

5.1 "A Reader's Perplexity over Dhirendra Premarshi's Hindi Ghazal": This is Kapari's finest piece of critical writing. On reading Premarshi's Hindi ghazal, his first response—"Good heavens, this is a Hindi ghazal!"—demonstrates a Maithili writer's linguistic commitment. Yet Kapari evaluates the ghazal with a wider vision: "When we look at and grasp the overall literary and linguistic grace of his composition, it must be conceded that his flow of language and his structural arrangement of the ghazal are distinctive and pleasing." This is a model of impartial criticism.

A principle of criticism: "A review of any work can become a clear and reasoned assessment only when it is undertaken without infatuation, with impartial feeling and a generous perspective." This sentence sums up Kapari's philosophy of criticism. A vision free of attachment and prejudice is extremely rare in Maithili reviewing.

5.2 "The Revolutionary Temper and Tone of Dr Vimal's Ghazals"

This is Kapari's most extensive piece of criticism. He makes a comprehensive evaluation of all three dimensions of Dr Rajendra Vimal's ghazals: their ideological stance, linguistic strength and revolutionary energy.

"Linking arm with arm, raise your voice with force / He has stolen our bread; tear open his belly."

Kapari comments on this couplet: "His anger here is extremely aggressive and explosive." This is a finely judged critical observation. Kapari makes implicit use of the Indian critical tradition's understanding of how rasa is produced.

A particularly important feature of Kapari's study of Vimal is its idea of the "ideological ghazal." Kapari says that Vimal's poems are filled with "social and cultural consciousness, values of life, devotion to one's own culture, and a strong resonance of commitment to ordinary people." This is the quality that transforms an ordinary ghazal into a "great ghazal."

Part Six: Autobiographical and Reminiscence Writing

6.1 "Even in My House, Maithili Is Highly Honoured": The episode of *sarāin*. Kapari calls his wife *sarāin*, a new feminine formation from *sar*. This linguistic invention is a distinctively Maithili example. "Just as the feminine of 'master' is *masterani*, so the feminine of 'doctor' is *doctorani*, and of 'lion' is *lioness*!" Such unpretentious humour reveals Kapari's personality. The piece also shows the sweetness of domestic life: "The mother of my child, grinding the mixture for *adauri* while singing *jantsari* songs." This is an exceptional record of rural life in Maithili prose.

6.2 "Women of Former Times … Grinding the Mixture for Adauri": This short composition compares women of earlier and later generations: the textured, carefully worked traditional designs against "fancy decoration." It is a touching comment on cultural change. "The mother of my child, grinding the paste for *adauri* and the gram-flour mixture for *tisiauri*, singing songs at the hand-mill": this picture deserves a place among the finest prose-poems in Maithili.

6.3 Birthdays of Children, Parents and Grandchildren: "Even when a sugar sweet is crooked, it tastes sweet all the same!" This saying of Kapari's elder sister is a fine example of folk wisdom. "What is little is little even in the womb!" His explanation of why the child Prabhu was named "Prithu," after King Prithu, reveals his awareness of tradition.

6.4 "The Development of Janakpurdham": Kapari writes continually about the Martyrs' Day of the Mithila movement, the deterioration of Janakpur Sub-Metropolitan City, the Parbaha festival and related matters. These writings exemplify social commitment. "May Mithila's martyrs live for ever!" is not merely a slogan but Kapari's philosophy of life. He has served as a coordinator of the Mithila State Struggle Committee, and this commitment is visible throughout his literature.

Part Seven: Theatrical Debate and Thought about the Stage

7.1 The Play "Reṅ-Reṅ": Ayodhyanath Chaudhary's response after reading "Reṅ-Reṅ"—"Colours and lines have a philosophy and psychology of their own"—attempts to connect the aesthetics of Mithila painting with theatrical craftsmanship. "This is not merely women's *kachni-bharni* line work; it is exalted by all the energy and impulse of modern pictorial art."

The comment places "Reṅ-Reṅ" at the meeting point of visual and dramatic arts.

7.2 The Development of Maithili Theatre

Kapari's writings on the Virat Maithili Dramatic Arts Council, the Janakpurdham International Theatre Festival and the Parbaha Cultural Festival are contemporary records of Maithili theatre history. He is not merely a spectator but an active participant and critic.

One important theatrical observation of Kapari's is that "Janakpur has many male and female actors, but lacks the principal tendencies of modern global theatre—stage philosophy, dramatic consciousness and artistic movements." This diagnosis is precise.

7.3 The Play "Tatkal Darshan": The discussion of the play's subject and technique and the publication of an English review by Dr Virendra Pandey illustrate the satisfaction of seeing Kapari's theatrical writing recognised internationally. Kapari emphasises "the play's substance, craftsmanship and stage technology, together with the practical arrangements for its performance." He is a practical theatre worker, not merely a theorist.

Part Eight: Historical and Mythological Narratives

8.1 "Alha-Rudal": This tale of the five Pandava brothers taking birth in the Kali age as Alha, Rudal, Brahmanand, Lakhan and Vir Malkhan is a beautiful union of mythology and folk ballad. Krishna fulfils Yudhishthira's frustrated wish—"Why was I unable to kill even one Kaurava in the Mahabharata?"—in the Kali age. The story gives the Maithili folk-ballad tradition a philosophical foundation. The cosmic context of the Alha-Rudal oral tradition, the rebirth of the Pandavas, lifts it above mere entertainment.

8.2 "Sitasakhi Gangasagar": A remarkable combination of mythological fantasy and contemporary social satire. The Gangasagar pond is personified as a "wizened old woman" who goes to the Mahakumbh. This is an excellent Maithili example of personification.

Part Nine: Children's Literature and Children's Songs

9.1 "Children's Folk Literature Overflowing with Joy and Entertainment": Kapari underscores the importance of Maithili folk literature for children. "This inexhaustible and priceless natural wealth will never grow stale": the observation reveals his serious attitude to children's literature. A play-song for Roshan Janakpuri's grandchild—"Hey, little scatterbrain, hey, little scatterbrain! / Why did you interrupt?"—displays the rhythms and playful nonsense that characterise Maithili songs for children, which Kapari seeks to preserve.

9.2 The Song-*Phakṛā* Tradition: The folk-song refrain from "Reṅ-Reṅ," with its comic swollen-throated speaker, brings the cultural energy of the play to life through folk style. Kapari incorporates the folk-song tradition into modern dramatic writing.

Part Ten: Overall Critical Assessment

10.1 The Writer's Strengths: The greatest strength of Parmeshwar Kapari's body of writing is the authenticity and vitality of his Maithili. Words such as *labakaniyā*, *haṛhaṛahī*, *dhatpatāe*, *chhagunāe*, *hapasi-lapaki* and *kutharait-batharait* testify to the language's living tradition. His second strength is courage and forthrightness. Whether in political satire, criticism of literary institutions or opposition to corruption, Kapari has never yielded to the lure of superficial popularity. His third strength is versatility. He moves easily across folk narrative, mythological storytelling, satire, autobiographical scenes, literary reviews, plays and philosophical essays.

10.2 Limitations and Points of Criticism: (a) Constraints of social-media writing. Many pieces were originally written as Facebook posts. The limitations of this medium—brevity and immediacy—sometimes restrict the depth of their subject matter. Kapari's talent could develop further in extended essays and research articles. (b) Personal attacks in satire. At times the satire descends to the personal level; criticism of Rambharos Kapari "Bhramar" and remarks about other writers occasionally take the shape of personal controversies rather than literary criticism. (c) Repetitiveness. Certain subjects—the Gen-Z movement or the struggle over the Maithili language—recur again and again. His creative range could expand still further.

10.3 Place in Videha Parallel History: Parmeshwar Kapari is an important pillar of the Videha parallel-literature movement. He establishes a distinctive identity for Nepal's Maithili literature outside the India-centred mainstream. He grants literary dignity to authentic Maithili speech and places folk tales, folk drama and folk songs on an equal footing with high literature. He unites the struggle for Mithila statehood with a literary and political campaign. Working outside the institutional system of literary prizes, he continues to honour his commitment to writing.

10.4 Comparative Position: Kapari brings together in his single personality the various strands of Maithili literature: cultural preservation, devotion to theatre, political realism and the energy of social movements. He is not merely a writer, but an entire cultural activist.

Conclusion

The literary world of Parmeshwar Kapari is a precious chapter in Maithili literature. The living language of folk tales, the philosophical substance of mythological narratives, the fearless pen of satire, the emotional force of autobiography and the impartiality of his literary criticism all testify to his many-sided talent. "The Mithila campaign is a very great undertaking": Kapari's own words sum up his philosophy of life. The cause of Mithila—its language, literature, culture and theatre—creates an integrated consciousness of Mithila. Kapari is a living representative of that consciousness.

Considered through all four perspectives—Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti; Western critical theory; Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya epistemology; and the Videha parallel-history framework—Kapari is an important, versatile, courageous and committed Maithili writer who deserves and needs a central place in Videha's parallel literary history.

Gajendra Thakur

A Critical Theory for the Maithili Stage and Drama (Part One)

With Reference to Parmeshwar Kapari's Play *Reṅ–Reṅ*

An Extended Literary Review

[Indian Aesthetics of Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti • Western Critical Theory • Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya • The Videha Parallel-History Framework]

1. An Introduction to the Life of the Writer Parmeshwar Kapari

1.1 Biographical Background

Parmeshwar Kapari is a Maithili writer, educationist and activist for Mithila and Maithili associated with Janakpurdham, Nepal. His work crosses genres, is experimental in character, and is deeply committed to social and cultural life. He formerly headed the Maithili Department at the Ra.Ra.B. Campus of Tribhuvan University in Janakpurdham. He also served as head of Tribhuvan University's Central Department of Maithili, making an invaluable contribution to teaching Maithili, literary research and the collection of folk literature.

An important feature of his personality is that he has simultaneously been a writer, an authentic student of folk literature, coordinator of the Mithila State Struggle Committee, and former member-secretary of the Maithili Development Fund. His place in contemporary Maithili literature is particularly noteworthy as an experimental and realist playwright. His literary production encompasses folk tales, plays, essays, critical writing, social commentary and cultural debate.

1.2 Literary Genres and Published Works

Parmeshwar Kapari's literary activities extend across several genres. Among his known writings are:

(a) Drama: *Reṅ–Reṅ*, a contemporary political and social satirical play associated with the Avantika Maithili Theatre Organisation in Janakpurdham, Nepal; (b) folk tales; (c) cultural essays; (d) social commentary; and (e) songs and *phakṛā* verses.

This variety makes clear that Kapari is not simply a scholar but also a creative, many-sided cultural worker. His central concerns are the people's language, the people themselves, and Mithila's cultural identity.

2. The Play *Reṅ–Reṅ*: Plot and Dramatic Craft

2.1 Introduction to the Play

Reṅ–Reṅ, a Maithili play written by Parmeshwar Kapari, is centred on the rehearsal space of the Avantika Maithili Theatre Organisation. Its title, *Reṅ–Reṅ*, is an onomatopoeic symbol, representing the differentiated colours of the stage, the changing colours of life, and the many-layered portrayal of social and political character.

The principal characters are Shridhar (the director), Anwar, Hamal, Akshara, Chhauṅṛā, Lakshmi/Aishwarya, Vishnu/Vivek, Bam Bahadur and Nunu Kaka. Together they represent the play's social class structure: artists, workers, divine powers, the police and the spirit of folk theatre.

2.2 Outline of the Plot

The play opens in an old landlord's building, where the Avantika Theatre Organisation is rehearsing. Shridhar is absorbed in reciting a poem: a song of invocation that expresses the desire to act upon the stage and to reconstruct society.

In the middle of the play Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth, appears. Her appearance, however, brings no divine blessing; it exposes a bitter truth about where wealth actually resides in society and how a corrupt system of government appropriates it. Poverty is the root of all sins: this is the play's central truth.

Vishnu, too, appears as a deity, but even he cannot distribute Lakshmi's gold. Bam Bahadur, the policeman, enters and arrests the performers. Finally Nunu Kaka appears as an embodiment of folk culture, revealing the truth through folk theatre. The play concludes with a marriage ceremony, a symbol of renewal and new life.

2.3 Stagecraft and Dramatic Technique

Reṅ–Reṅ is composed in the manner of epic theatre. Changes in vocal inflection, shifts from emotional absorption to political sloganeering, dance and song bring it close to Brecht's *Verfremdungseffekt*, or alienation technique. The play employs five principal dramatic devices:

(1) Vocal modulation and shifts in inflection as an estrangement effect.

(2) Waves of colour as a metaphorical device for changing scenes.

(3) Episodic structure: a sequence of discontinuous scenes.

(4) Changes of rhythm through folk songs, *humarī* and the style of political slogans.

(5) Metatheatre: a play that refers to its own theatricality.

3. A Fourfold Method of Analysis

According to the Videha parallel-history framework, this review rests on four pillars: (a) the Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti; (b) Western critical theory; (c) Navya-Nyāya, particularly Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya; and (d) the Videha parallel-history framework itself.

3.1 Indian Aesthetics of Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti

3.1.1 The Theory of Rasa: The Dominant Rasas in the Play

In the light of Bharata Muni's *Nāṭyaśāstra*, with its nine dramatic rasas, and Abhinavagupta's *Abhinavabhāratī*, with its theory of aesthetic relish, the rasas of *Reṅ–Reṅ* may be analysed as follows:

Principal Rasa: Karuṇa, or Compassion

The tragedy of poverty, the suffering of unemployed artists, and the scene in which Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth, departs empty-handed constitute the basis of the enduring emotion that sustains the play's compassionate rasa. The lament "Poverty is a disease" keeps the entire drama immersed in an atmosphere of pathos.

The Rasa of Satire (Hāsya and Raudra): A Dual Aesthetic Experience

The playwright establishes a remarkable tension between Bharata's hāsya, the comic rasa, and raudra, the furious rasa. Bam Bahadur's entry as a policeman and Lakshmi's departure combine laughter and anger. According to Abhinavagupta's theory of *rasābhāsa*, what occurs here is not the complete awakening of a rasa but an incomplete, disturbed experience. This situation recurs throughout *Reṅ–Reṅ*.

Vīra Rasa: The Final Resistance

Anwar and Vivek's fearless resistance in the prison scene, together with the revelation of truth through folk theatre, expresses the heroic rasa. The declaration "Om Khambrahman—Suga Ṛtasya Panthā" marks its culmination.

3.1.2 The Theory of Dhvani: Ānandavardhana's Perspective

According to Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka* (850 CE), suggestion, or *dhvani*—the level of meaning beyond the literal, expressed sense—is paramount in accomplished poetry. Three levels of suggestion are discernible in *Reṅ–Reṅ*:

The first level is literal: *Reṅ–Reṅ* is the sound associated with colour. The second is metaphorical: it suggests the changing colours of life. The third

is political: it signifies the fragmentation of popular culture under corrupt rule.

The play's title is itself a many-voiced sign in which *raṅg* (colour and stage), *rog* (disease, embodied in poverty), *raṇ* (struggle) and *reṅ* (the sound of a suppressed cry) resonate together.

3.1.3 Vakrokti: Kuntaka's Perspective

According to Kuntaka's tenth-century *Vakroktijīvita*, oblique expression —language that deviates from simple denotation—is fundamental to accomplished poetry and drama. *Reṅ–Reṅ* provides several examples:

(a) Vishnu's appearance is satirical rather than divine: he utters only a couple of cursory remarks and leaves.

(b) Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth, goes away empty-handed—the most strikingly oblique statement of all.

(c) The recitation associated with Satyanarayan worship becomes a satirical religious ceremony in the midst of poverty.

(d) The gold *ashrafī* coin symbolises a dream of riches that turns to ashes: an oblique system of symbols.

3.2 Western Critical Theory

3.2.1 Brechtian Epic Theatre

Bertolt Brecht's (1898–1956) theory of epic theatre offers the closest Western counterpart to *Reṅ–Reṅ*. The Brechtian *Verfremdungseffekt*, or estrangement effect, is expressed in the play in the following ways:

(a) Altered voice and gesture, as well as songs and dances within the performance, prevent the spectator from becoming wholly absorbed in emotional identification and instead prompt rational reflection; these devices exemplify Brechtian *Gestus*. (b) The repeated slogan "Poverty is a disease" employs Brecht's song technique. (c) Anwar and Akshara's awkward exchanges over a mobile telephone in the prison scene connect the spectator with contemporary reality.

3.2.2 Marxist Dramatic Criticism

In the light of Raymond Williams's *Drama from Ibsen to Brecht* (1952) and Terry Eagleton's *Marxism and Literary Criticism* (1976), the class struggle in *Reṅ–Reṅ* may be examined as follows:

The ruling class (the police, the government, and Vishnu as a divine guardian of the status quo), the class of artists (Shridhar, Anwar, Hamal and Akshara, all unemployed performers), and the folk class (Nunu Kaka

and Chhauṅṛā) constitute a triangular conflict that dramatizes Marxist class struggle. The accumulation, distribution and ultimately disappointing disappearance of gold, representing capital, form a metaphor for capitalist accumulation.

3.2.3 A Postcolonial Perspective

In the light of Homi Bhabha's *The Location of Culture* (1994) and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988):

The debate over language in *Reṅ–Reṅ*—Maithili as against Nepali, Hindi, English, Sanskrit and Urdu, and the dispute over which language should be inscribed upon Vishnu's gold coin—is an outstanding postcolonial scene of hybridity. The playwright creates Bhabha's "Third Space," in which no single language or culture remains dominant. Nunu Kaka's entrance, embodying the spirit of folk theatre, invokes Bharata Muni's argument for the "Fifth Veda" to challenge colonial and Brahmanical-Sanskritic dominance.

3.2.4 Feminist Criticism

An analysis of Akshara's character in the light of Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (1990) and Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (1949):

Akshara is the only female character who speaks out boldly in the play. She proposes a love marriage to Hamal, the protagonist, and speaks fearlessly to the police. Yet in the Lakshmi episode a tension emerges between women's economic power, personified by the goddess of wealth, and patriarchal economic authority—a tension that can be understood through Butler's concept of performativity.

3.2.5 Chinese Literary Theory

In the light of the Chinese theory of *jingjie*, or the realm of aesthetic experience; Wang Guowei's *Renjian Cihua* (1908–1910); and the *feng* tradition of satire in classical Chinese theatre:

The political satire of *Reṅ–Reṅ* is comparable to the satirical elements of Chinese *zaju*, the musical drama of the Yuan dynasty, and *Kunqu* opera. In these traditions, humorous criticism of the ruling class's folly, a story-within-a-story structure, and the poetic use of folk melodies are central. An awareness of poverty (*pínkùn yìshí*) and the desire for social justice are shared focal points of the two traditions.

3.3 Navya-Nyāya: The Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

3.3.1 Direct Perception and Dramatic Truth

The epistemology of *Reṅ–Reṅ* may be examined in the light of *pratyakṣa*, direct perceptual knowledge, as expounded in the perception section of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's *Tattvacintāmaṇi*. Gaṅgeśa was active in Mithila around 1320 CE.

The direct experience of poverty expressed in Anwar's "We are dying of hunger" constitutes *nirvikalpaka pratyakṣa*, or indeterminate perception. The manifestation of Lakshmi and the shower of gold constitute *savikalpaka pratyakṣa*, or determinate perception, which is ultimately exposed as false. This is a dramatic expression of Gaṅgeśa's account of perceptual illusion.

3.3.2 Inference and the Play's Chain of Reasoning

Gaṅgeśa's concept of *vyāptigraha*, the apprehension of invariable concomitance that makes inference possible, provides the basis of the central argument of *Reṅ–Reṅ*:

Vyāpti: "As long as there is poverty, there will be every disease." In other words, where poverty exists, every form of suffering exists. This is the play's *hetu*, or logical reason. *Sādhya*: "Poverty causes every disease." In other words, all affliction proceeds from poverty. The critique presents this as the play's *pakṣa*, the subject of inference.

Through the Navya-Nyāya technique of *parāmarśa*, or subsumptive reflection, the playwright presents Shridharam's speech as a philosophical and logical declaration.

3.3.3 Verbal Testimony and the Dispute over Language

A significant scene in the play concerns the language to be used on the gold *ashrafī*: Maithili, Nepali, Hindi, English, Sanskrit or Urdu? It becomes a dramatic test of Gaṅgeśa's theory of *śabda-pramāṇa*, knowledge derived from verbal testimony. According to Gaṅgeśa, testimony is valid when its speaker is *āpta*, or trustworthy. The question of linguistic dominance in the play therefore raises two questions: which language's words carry authority, and which speaker is to be considered *āpta*?

3.4 The Videha Parallel-History Framework

3.4.1 The Counter-Canon and Parmeshwar Kapari

The central contention of the Videha parallel-literary-history movement is that much has been excluded from the "mainstream" history of Maithili

literature centred on the Sahitya Akademi in New Delhi and the Nepal Academy—particularly Maithili writers in Nepal, marginal authors and the tradition of folk theatre.

Parmeshwar Kapari represents one of these excluded groups. His *Reṅ–Reṅ*:

(a) Represents Maithili theatre centred on Janakpurdham, Nepal.

(b) Directly makes the Sahitya Akademi's institutional dominance an object of satire.

(c) Places folk theatre, through the Nunu Kaka episode, on an equal footing with classical drama.

(d) Places the struggle of unemployed performers at the centre—an experience absent from mainstream literary history.

3.4.2 *Reṅ–Reṅ* in a Parallel History of Maithili Theatre

Reṅ–Reṅ occupies a distinctive position in the history of Maithili drama. The response of Ayodhyanath Chaudhary, the distinguished Maithili writer, shows that the play accurately delineates the truth of its age, the reality of the people, and a political climate shaped by the Gen-Z movement—the rebellious movement of a younger generation.

4. Comparative Study: Other Maithili Playwrights and Writers

Where the mainstream is absorbed in historicity and cultural revival, Kapari focuses on contemporary political reality. In technique, mainstream drama tends to observe the classical three unities of place, time and action more closely, while *Reṅ–Reṅ* adopts the open structure of epic theatre.

Comparison with Mahendra Malangia

Where Mahendra Malangia raised folk theatre chiefly to an aesthetic plane, Kapari turns it into a weapon of political resistance. Both playwrights employ satire as a primary literary instrument in Maithili literature: Malangia within a more limited dramatic form, Kapari in a freer one. Their central concerns differ. Malangia addresses the problems of a restricted social group, whereas Kapari writes, like Bechan Thakur, against unemployment and corrupt institutions and in defence of Maithili identity.

The character "Shridharam," the director, may be a satirical allusion to Nepal's institutional Maithili literary establishment.

The dramatic tradition of Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrta-Samāgama* and Vidyapati's *Gorakṣavijaya*—the latter Vidyapati being distinguished here from the earlier Vidyapati preceding Jyotirishwar—echoes in the Nunu

Kaka episode. Bharata Muni's *Nāṭyaśāstra* and the argument that drama constitutes a "Fifth Veda" are directly connected to this tradition. Kapari re-establishes it in a contemporary political context.

5. Critical Evaluation: Strengths and Limitations

5.1 The Distinctive Strengths of the Play

(a) A successful fusion of folk theatre and modern political drama.

The most significant achievement of *Reṅ–Reṅ* is its transformation of the *phakṛā* verses of Maithili folk theatre into an instrument of contemporary political theatre. In this respect it goes beyond Brecht's epic theatre, for its aesthetic roots lie in a local folk tradition.

(b) Linguistic plurality and cultural dialogue.

The presence of Maithili, Nepali, Hindi, Sanskrit, Urdu and English within the play is itself a cultural and political statement. The reality of Maithili identity in Nepal, where it exists within a multilingual region, comes alive in this experience.

(c) Metatheatre: the play within the play.

Reṅ–Reṅ is itself metatheatre: it tells the story of a theatre organisation rehearsing a play, and the rehearsal turns into a social drama. This play-within-a-play structure is rare in Maithili drama.

(d) The Aishwarya/Lakshmi scene as an economic metaphor.

Lakshmi's shower of gold, its seizure by greed-driven characters, and her eventual departure empty-handed constitute an outstanding metaphorical portrayal of the capitalist economy, fulfilling the expectations of Marxist criticism.

5.2 Limitations and Points for Criticism

(a) The final marriage scene, in which Hamal and Akshara are married, seems somewhat inconsistent with the play's political edge. Such a conclusion suggests a concession to commercial theatre.

(b) Nunu Kaka's argument about the "Fifth Veda," the philosophical high point of the play, could have been developed at greater length.

(c) The characters have unequal psychological depth. Shridharam and Anwar are well developed, whereas Chhauṅṛā and Bam Bahadur at times lapse into oversimplified stereotypes.

6. The Literary Significance of the Playwright and His Play

6.1 Contribution to Maithili Theatre

Reṅ–Reṅ gives the Maithili theatre of Nepal a new dimension. It demonstrates that:

(a) Maithili drama can be placed within the context of world-class political theatre.

(b) The folk-theatre tradition is not "primitive" but a vehicle for the most modern ideas.

(c) The struggles of unemployed, marginal Maithili performers constitute a serious literary subject.

(d) Janakpurdham, a centre of Nepalese Maithili theatre, possesses its own tradition independently of the history centred on Darbhanga.

6.2 Place in Videha Parallel History

Within the framework of the Videha parallel-literature movement, Parmeshwar Kapari is a writer who:

(a) Continues his literary work outside the institutional apparatus; (b) links the folk-literary tradition with modern political theatre; (c) gives literary expression to the struggle for Maithili identity in Nepal; and (d) brings Mithila's cultural riches into dialogue with modern thought.

Together these features give substance to "What the Canon Left Out," the subtitle of Videha's parallel history.

7. Conclusion

Parmeshwar Kapari's *Reṅ–Reṅ* is a Maithili play that shows life as though it were taking place upon a stage. Poverty, corruption and unemployment among performers are all diseases. Yet the playwright is not a pessimist. Through folk theatre, the power of the Fifth Veda and the symbol of a new marriage, he seeks to convey a message of irrepressible hope.

Viewed in the light of the Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti; Western epic theatre; the Chinese tradition of satirical drama; and Gaṅgeśa's Navya-Nyāya epistemology, *Reṅ–Reṅ* is a rich, many-layered composition that gives Maithili drama a new dimension.

Within the framework of Videha parallel literary history, Kapari is an important playwright marginalised by mainstream literary historiography, whose *Reṅ–Reṅ* retains an unforgettable place in the history of Maithili theatre.

Gajendra Thakur

A Critical Theory for the Maithili Stage and Drama (Part Two): With Reference to Parmeshwar Kapari's Play *Gahan Ugarās*

Gahan Ugarās — Parmeshwar Kapari

A Multidimensional Review in Dramatic Theory

The Historical Background and Publication of *Gahan Ugarās*

Parmeshwar Kapari's *Gahan Ugarās* is a landmark in contemporary Maithili drama and experimental theatre. The first edition was published in Phagun 2073 of the Vikram Samvat calendar by Prithu Prakashan, Janakpurdham. Written as an entirely original dramatic work, the book carries a cover painting by the celebrated Mithila artist S. C. Suman; its setting and design were undertaken by Kumar Bhaskar. Kapari dedicated this distinctive play to the renowned and historic Maithili theatre practitioner Kunalji, whose work on stage and whose dramatic creativity have brought lasting honour to the Maithili language and literature.

Dr Abhi Subedi, an eminent scholar of Nepalese theatre, calls the play's structure "experimental." He writes that Kapari creates the stage through human dialogue and the internal relationships between speakers instead of relying upon conventional scenic arrangements or artificial scenography. The principal character is a landlord, and social relationships continually form and disintegrate around him. Parmeshwar Kapari is known for confronting established systems. He is himself a living dictionary of Maithili, as the authentic and abundant vocabulary of *Gahan Ugarās* amply demonstrates.

Historically, Janakpurdham has been the theatrical and cultural capital of the Mithila region within Nepal. A principal source of its vitality was the Mithila Natya Kala Parishad (MINAP), founded in 1979, whose energy sustained Maithili theatrical consciousness. By the end of the twentieth century, however, the untimely death of Dhirendra Dhumketu had begun to diminish Janakpur's theatre. At the same time the Patna theatre scene in India also fell into inactivity; obscene orchestras occupied traditional village stages, and people who turned Vidyapati festivals into enterprises of subscription collection began to stigmatise deserving individuals rather than honour them with a ceremonial *pāg*. Mahendra Malangia's slapstick humour continued to ridicule the proletariat. In this darkness, institutions such as MINAP, Akriti, Achhinjal and Bhangima brought about a revival of Maithili theatre in Janakpur. It was then that Ramesh Ranjan appeared with *Sakhi*, and Parmeshwar Kapari with *Gahan Ugarās*, both drawing

upon the realities produced by Nepal's ten-year Maoist people's war and the upheaval of the Second People's Movement.

Dramatic Structure, Symbolic Design and Sociopolitical Reality

The plot of *Gahan Ugarās* is principally divided into two parts, which present, through metaphor, a historical discourse on Nepal's transition from feudalism, the social repercussions of the people's war and cultural colonisation. Its opening historical setting is the political crisis of the regressive period following Nepal's Second People's Movement (Vikram Samvat 2062–63). The repression of monarchy and the autocratic Panchayat order is weakening, but Gyanendra's government is making a final coercive attempt to retain power. Meanwhile a new movement for a federal republic through a Constituent Assembly is spreading across the country.

A Close Analysis of the First Part

The first part opens at the crumbling house of the Rajput landlord Phulgen Singh, a remnant of feudalism whose granaries contain not a single grain. The landlord's children live elsewhere, while a Dhanuk villager, Manejara, looks after him and prepares his food. The irritable old landlord Phulgen Singh, his knees and back wrapped in a *gamchhā*, swats flies while recalling his former feudal prestige. Two impudent, impish village children, Tunma and Musna, mock him on his veranda with traditional songs: "The elephant has arrived, the horse has arrived; at this old fellow's wedding the grandson will lead the procession," and "Reṅ, reṅ, reṅ—a frog on your plate." Two young girls playing *Jaṭ-Jaṭin* expose his exploitative character by singing: "This landlord is the master of the village, isn't he? He cheats the measure on the scales, doesn't he?"

At this point a middle-aged woman named Sati enters. She restrains the landlord's abusive language and warns him that the days of feudal oppression have passed, and that he can now expect to be beaten with shoes and kicks. Five revolutionary young people then enter the stage:

Phulo Khatbe: a militant Dalit human-rights activist.

Dukhiya Sada: a voice of the oppressed, appearing as a representative of Amnesty International.

Subhadra Mandal: an active political worker.

Jwala Prasad Singh (Jwala): an underground fighter in the Maoist people's war who has taken up arms to put an end to exploitation.

Vidyapati Yadav: an outspoken journalist and media worker who uses his pen to expose the exploiting class.

The landlord boasts of his ancestral feudal power: "Your fathers and grandfathers grazed cattle at the mansion, and your wives were servants there." In fury, the Maoist fighter Jwala Singh strikes him with a blow, and the old landlord falls trembling to the ground. The young people depart to report on and participate in a major political meeting against regression. Soon afterwards a servant runs in and, weeping, tells the old man Khokhna and an elderly woman that the police have opened indiscriminate fire at the political meeting at the school. Sati has been shot twice in the chest and has died; Jwala Singh was killed instantly; Phulo is breathing her last; and Subhadra and Vidyapati are in critical condition.

The Second Part: Metaphor and Cultural Debate

The second part begins as a surreal and allegorical journey. Baba Abhelba and his paralysed disciple Baklelba, who walks with a shaking gait as though pounding rice, head towards Janakpurdham carrying a *tumrī*, a water vessel and a blanket, and singing the devotional refrain "Laṭak Saṭak Siyārāmā." Even after his bundle slips from his head, the disciple continues singing *jogirā*. In Janakpurdham they meet Lakhna, Bechna, Mangla and Janka, who have gathered there to sleep. Janka Mallah narrates the marriage of Rama and Sita during the Vivah Panchami celebrations. He says that after the wedding Dasharatha insisted upon a dowry, whereupon Janaka placed his own head before Dasharatha. The story becomes a metaphor for Mithila's seemingly endless cultural exploitation.

Meanwhile Genma and Phaguni hear the earth weeping. Everyone begins to dig and discovers a stream of thick, bright-red blood. Vidyapati explains that this blood comes from the repression carried out by the Gorkha Shah dynasty 230–240 years earlier. Remains of the Maithili language, culture and arts lie buried in the soil, destroyed by the coercive "One Language, One Dress" policy. At the call of Bulanti and Dukhiya, the women sing songs of renewal—*Chhathi* songs, *Chaitāwar*, and *Jaṭ-Jaṭin*. At the end, Vidyapati leads a great revolutionary procession for the release of Maithili from its "deep eclipse," its *gahan ugarās*, and for the establishment of an autonomous Mithila province in a new federal Nepal.

1. General Introduction and Structure of the Book

Parmeshwar Kapari's Maithili play *Gahan Ugarās*—a dialectal form of "release from an eclipse"—is an expression of profound social suffering. It was published by Prithu Prakashan, Janakpurdham, in Phagun 2073. Divided into two parts, the play develops its dramatic action around the sociopolitical circumstances of Nepal's Mithila region. Its cast contains representatives of many social groups: the landlord Phulgen Singh, an oppressive feudal figure; Tunma and Musna, comic children; Girl One and Girl Two, voices of female rebellion; Phekua, a young man; the Heroine,

symbolising new cultural distortions; Bulanti, Subansh, Subhadra, Jwala, Dukhiya, Phulo and Sati, belonging to the proletarian community; an old man and an old woman; Vidyapati, a symbolic embodiment of cultural consciousness; Janka, Bechna and Lakhna, representing different strata of Mithila's social life; and the Telephone Man, representing modern means of communication. This diversity of characters itself demonstrates the playwright's desire to exclude no section of society from the stage.

2. From the Perspective of Indian Dramaturgy

A Comparison with Indian Dramatic Theory and the "Theatre of Roots"

The rasa theory of Indian dramaturgy—especially *karuṇa*, *vīra* and *raudra*—fully animates *Gahan Ugarās*. Suresh Awasthi's "Theatre of Roots" movement sought to revitalise indigenous folk forms in opposition to colonial Western realist theatre. Habib Tanvir, Ratan Thiyam, B. V. Karanth and K. N. Panikkar joined folk rituals and indigenous traditions to modern political consciousness.

In *Gahan Ugarās*, Parmeshwar Kapari presents the philosophy of this roots movement in a new form within Maithili theatre. Traditional forms of *nāch*, such as *Jaṭ-Jaṭin*, *Jhijhiya* and folk song, had often been treated as mere entertainment, without a written script. Rambharos Kapari "Bhramar" and Parmeshwar Kapari, however, transformed this folk dance into a forceful political weapon against class oppression and colonial domination. When the *Jaṭ-Jaṭin* song sounds in the second part, its dialogue expresses the harsh reality of migrant life. The result is a living, dynamic folk tradition—the central principle of the Theatre of Roots.

Four Traditions of Theatre Theory in Gahan Ugarās

Tradition of dramatic theory	Principal exponents / underlying philosophy	Concrete application and analysis in Gahan Ugarās
Indian Theatre of the Roots	Suresh Awasthi, Habib Tanvir and Ratan Thiyam	Traditional Jat-Jatin, Jhijhiya, Chhath songs and folk narrative (Janaka's self-sacrifice) become vehicles for class conflict and political revolution.
Western epic theatre	Bertolt Brecht	Breaking the illusion of the fourth wall; drawing spectators into logical and ideological critique rather than mere sentiment; symbolic acting.
Chinese xieyi theatre	Mei Lanfang and Huang Zuolin	Fluidity, flexibility, three-dimensionality and formal convention; a direct transition from the present into the oppressive Simraungarh of 250 years earlier.

Tradition of dramatic theory	Principal exponents / underlying philosophy	Concrete application and analysis in Gahan Ugarās
Jewish Yiddish theatre	Abraham Goldfaden and Itzik Manger	Indigenous farce comparable to Purimshpils and Broder singers; analogy between the pain of Gulf migration and the trauma of Yiddish displacement.

(a) The Five Junctures and the Structure of Dramatic Action

Bharata Muni's *Nāṭyaśāstra* divides dramatic action into five junctures: *mukha*, *pratimukha*, *garbha*, *vimarśa* and *nirvahaṇa*. In this framework, the *mukha* of *Gahan Ugarās* appears in the opening scene: the landlord's granary is empty, and the children Tunma and Musna mock him in song as they play in his courtyard. The *pratimukha* emerges when the wave of the people's movement begins to challenge the landlord's power. The *garbha* arises with the Heroine's entrance, raising the problems of cultural disintegration and economic migration. The *vimarśa* is expressed when the proletarian community, in the symbolic presence of Vidyapati, searches for a path to liberation. The *nirvahaṇa*, the point of resolution, is not clearly present. This constitutes a major shortcoming in terms of Indian dramaturgy.

(b) The Theory of Rasa

Indian dramatic theory recognises eight or nine rasas. *Karuṇa* flows most powerfully through *Gahan Ugarās*: in the lament of the elderly couple, in the women's song of departure for distant lands, and in Bulanti's grief at separation from her only son. *Vīra* emerges in the second part's scenes of popular agitation. *Bībhatsa* is felt in the descriptions of the landlord's oppression. *Hāsya* appears in the children Tunma and Musna's playful, satirical exchanges. But *śṛṅgāra*, which Bharata Muni regards as the king of rasas, is almost entirely absent. Seen through the commentator Abhinavagupta's theory of suggestive rasa, the play's language possesses considerable power of suggestion, but because it lacks sufficient literary refinement, *dhvani* does not achieve its fullest development.

(c) Types of Hero and the Classification of Characters

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* names four heroic types: *dhīrodātta*, *dhīroddhata*, *dhīralalita* and *dhīrapraśānta*. *Gahan Ugarās* has no single central hero. Vidyapati functions symbolically as the serene *dhīrapraśānta* hero, summoning a cultural awakening. The people collectively constitute the protagonist, a choice closer to Indian folk theatre than to classical Sanskrit drama. This may be understood as a deliberate dramaturgical decision.

(d) Number of Acts and Dramatic Form

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* describes ten dramatic forms, including *nāṭaka*, *prakaraṇa*, *bhāṇa*, *vyāyoga* and *samavakāra*. *Gahan Ugarās* departs from the characteristics of the classical *nāṭaka* and comes closer to *prakaraṇa*, since it depicts the realities of social life rather than a royal plot. Within folk theatre, however, it is still more closely associated with the traditions of *Vidapat Nāch*, *Jaṭ-Jaṭin* and the collective singing of *Sama-Chakeva*. The way women enter the stage with headcloths tied and cultural songs on their lips represents the living continuity of Mithila's folk-theatre tradition.

3. From the Perspective of Western Dramatic Theory

A Comparative Reading through Western and Chinese Theatre Theory

The Western playwright Bertolt Brecht's theories of epic theatre and the *Verfremdungseffekt*, or alienation effect, distance spectators from emotional absorption in the plot so that they can examine it rationally. Brecht's theory was influenced by traditional Chinese theatrical styles, especially Mei Lanfang's acting. Chinese theatre breaks the "fourth wall" to address spectators directly.

Huang Zuolin, a pioneer of Chinese spoken drama (*huaju*), described a related approach as *xieyi*, or essentialist theatre. Its principal qualities are fluidity, flexibility, sculpturality and conventionality.

The dramatic craft of *Gahan Ugarās* is a Maithili adaptation of both *xieyi* and Brechtian principles. According to Dr Abhi Subedi, rather than constructing a realistic scenic environment, the play builds the stage through the dialogue and relationships of its characters. Changes of scene are exceptionally fluid and flexible: without lowering a curtain, the action moves straight from the present to the repression and historical displacement at Simraungadh some 240 years earlier. Baklelba's trembling walk and the landlord's posture with his staff demonstrate the use of symbolic, conventionalised movement.

Comparison with Yiddish Dramaturgy and the Discourse of Displacement

Yiddish theatre developed among the Ashkenazi Jews of Eastern Europe in their Yiddish language. Its roots include the *Purimshpil* farces performed during the festival of Purim, which sharply attacked contemporary social contradictions and the wealthy classes. The satirical plays associated with Maithili's Vivah Panchami tableaux and MINAP's *Mahāmūrkha Sammelan* are remarkably close to the realistic and humorous style of the *Purimshpil*.

The "Broder Singers" of Yiddish theatre were itinerant musicians who changed costumes and performed satirical, humorous farces; from this tradition Abraham Goldfaden laid the foundation of professional Yiddish theatre. The children's farce at landlord Phulgen Singh's door in the opening scene of *Gahan Ugarās*, and the comic scenes of Baba Abhelba and his disciple Baklelba in its second part, resemble the indigenous, humorous theatrical techniques of the Broder Singers.

In considering the conflict within Yiddish theatre between *shund*, or popular "trash theatre," and literary theatre, Itsik Manger wrote that *shund* was in fact a "free stage" without academicised acting, where popular desires found spontaneous expression. A similar conflict has existed in Maithili theatre between *shund* forms, such as folk *nāch* and the *kīrtaniyā*, and refined literary drama. *Gahan Ugarās* bridges that division by linking popular culture with political liberation.

Displacement, Employment Abroad and the Pain of Nostalgia

Diaspora, migration and nostalgia have been among the most important foundations of Yiddish theatre. Poor Jews who emigrated from Eastern Europe to America sang songs such as "Mayn Shtetele Belz" and performed plays in memory of their *shtetl*, or Jewish village, to relieve their sorrows.

Gahan Ugarās presents this tragedy of modern Maithil displacement with considerable force. The telephone conversation between a Maithil migrant labourer, Mundha, trapped in the oppressive *kafala* system in Gulf countries such as Qatar and Saudi Arabia, and the "Gulf widow" (the Heroine), who lives alone at home, is a Maithili adaptation of the dramaturgy of Yiddish displacement. Here anxiety about AIDS, the use of condoms and the torment of suspicions about sexual conduct expose the pain of nostalgia and the harsh realities of migrant life.

(a) Aristotle's Theory of Mimesis and the Three Unities

Aristotle argues in the *Poetics* that tragedy imitates the actions of a noble person and generates *catharsis*, a purification of the spectator's emotions. *Gahan Ugarās* does not strictly observe the three unities of time, place and action. Its settings shift among a village, a police station, a fairground and a Jūṛśītal bathing place, while the action seems to stretch over years. Yet one of the most important Aristotelian elements, unity of action, is partially present: all the incidents revolve around the central struggle for liberation from oppression.

In the light of Aristotle's theory of great tragedy, *peripeteia*, or reversal of fortune, can be seen in the landlord's decline. Once all-powerful, he is finally mocked by children singing, "Turn out the dog, and chase away the cat." But *anagnorisis*, the moment of recognition, is clearly absent; this

prevents the play from attaining the structure of a complete classical tragedy.

(b) The Brechtian Influence: Theatre of Distanciation

The most apparent influence upon *Gahan Ugarās* is the German playwright's anti-individualising dramatic method. In his foreword, Dr Abhi Subedi explicitly calls the work "experimental" and writes, in Nepali, that "human beings themselves, rather than scenic arrangements or 'scenography,' create the stage, and they themselves have given *Gahan Ugarās* its dramatic body." In keeping with Brecht's epic-theatre tradition, the narrative thread repeatedly breaks, the characters sing songs of the people and disrupt theatrical illusion, and the spectators are invited to respond intellectually rather than identify emotionally.

Tunma and Musna's comic song—"The elephant has arrived, the horse has arrived; at this old man's wedding the grandson will lead the procession"—is a clear Brechtian intervention. It forces spectators to look consciously at the grotesque contradictions of reality.

(c) Stanislavski's Psychological Realism

From the perspective of Stanislavski, who emphasised profound investigation of a character's inner life, *Gahan Ugarās* offers relatively little psychological depth. Bulanti's grief at separation from her son and the Heroine's conflict over her double life provide a few sensitive dramatic moments, but characterisation as a whole remains incomplete. In this respect the playwright has chosen to privilege social purpose over the development of individual personalities.

(d) Existentialist Theatre

Viewed through the existentialist thought of Camus and Sartre, the play carries an echo of inward sorrow: people remain alive, but the social order deprives their lives of meaning. Bulanti's outcry that her son has fled from home and she has not seen his face expresses the existential pain of a disconnected life without discernible destiny.

4. From the Perspective of Israeli Dramatic Thought

The Israeli playwright Hanoch Levin (1943–1999), a central figure of modern Israeli theatre, was accomplished in dramatising political satire and the suffering of ordinary people. The satirical exchanges directed against the landlord in *Gahan Ugarās*, the mockery of authority in the mouths of children and the collective songs of protest resemble Levin's sharpness and directness. Just as the anguished voice of the ordinary citizen becomes the language of Israeli theatre, Kapari carries out a parallel task

upon the soil of Mithila. Yet *Gahan Ugarās* does not fully attain the philosophical density discernible in the Israeli theatrical tradition.

5. From the Perspective of Chinese Theatre

The Chinese theatrical tradition, especially Yuan opera and the political theatre that followed the Mao era, is distinguished by its combination of song, dance and dialogue, through which collective consciousness speaks. The repeated use of folk songs in *Gahan Ugarās*—songs of Jūṛśītal, Holi, the ceremonial headcloth, and opposition to dowry—has a functional resemblance to this Chinese dramatic style. The staging of Vidyapati as a historical and cultural symbol of Mithila recalls the Chinese practice of making historical and mythological figures carry contemporary political messages.

6. The Principal Distinctive Features of the Play

First, political forthrightness. The play brings Nepal's monarchy, the Maoist people's war, the Second People's Movement, Gyanendra's regressive rule and the establishment of the federal democratic republic directly onto the stage, making it a form of explicit political testimony. The Indian part of Mithila now stands outside this history while witnessing its theatrical presentation: the work is thus produced in a particular geographical and cultural situation.

Second, linguistic stratification. There is a clear difference between the language of the landlord and that of the workers, as well as differences in tone between female and male characters. Vidyapati's dialogue is literary and exhortatory. The Telephone Man becomes a vehicle for satire on modern communication culture. Such a many-layered linguistic structure is the mark of a mature dramatist.

Third, the importance of women's voices. Girl One and Girl Two openly insult and taunt the landlord: "On this old fellow's griddle, fry two lumps of jaggery; set the dogs barking and the cats yowling." Bulanti and Subhadra likewise raise voices of resistance. Through the forceful presence of these female characters, the play challenges Mithila's patriarchal social order in dramatic language.

Fourth, the incorporation of cultural and ritual elements. Sprinkling water on Jūṛśītal, the Holi festival, folk songs and the tying of ceremonial headcloths are woven naturally into the dramatic plot. They raise *Gahan Ugarās* above a merely political drama and turn it into a document of cultural memory.

Fifth, criticism of the dowry system. In an important scene, Lakhna, Janka and Bechna together expose dowry through satire. The exchange, "Remember, it was at King Janaka's palace that the dowry custom began

among us," introduces a satirical perspective that connects King Janaka's cultural prestige with a social evil.

7. The Play's Principal Limitations

First, looseness of plot. There is no tightly controlled sequence of events. One scene is often linked to the next by coincidence rather than causation. Neither Bharata Muni's *sūtradhāra* tradition nor Brecht's clearly articulated scene divisions provide a guiding structure. The spectator or reader must piece the narrative together independently.

Second, incomplete character development. Vidyapati's symbolic appearance is ambitious, but its dramatic potential is not fully exploited. The Heroine is made a symbol of cultural distortion, yet the deeper socioeconomic causes of her situation remain unexplored. The landlord is a one-dimensional oppressor lacking human complexity.

Third, ambiguity about the ending. The final scene brings processions, slogans and agitation together without a clear dramatic resolution. The line "Remove the eclipse that has fallen upon society and culture" justifies the play's title, but this poetic ending is not a dramatic ending. The absence both of the *nirvahaṇa-sandhi* required in Indian dramaturgy and of the *denouement* expected in Western drama is a creative limitation.

Fourth, the complexity of staging. The many locations, numerous characters, folk-music performances and sounds of movements arriving from distant places make the production exceptionally difficult on the resource-constrained stages of Mithila, although not impossible.

Dr Abhi Subedi writes in his introduction that "The play will pass the director's test one hundred per cent, and the audience's test even more readily." From this perspective its stageability is not a limitation.

8. The Historical Significance of the Play

Gahan Ugarās is an important work in the literature of Maithili drama in Nepalese Mithila. It may be regarded as a distinctive representative of the theatrical tradition that developed after the establishment of the Mithila Natya Kala Parishad in Janakpur in 1979.

9. Conclusions from an Integrated Comparison of Dramatic Theories

Gahan Ugarās is an ambitious effort, motivated by political and social concerns, to link the folk-theatre tradition with modern political drama. It succeeds notably in the compassionate rasa of Indian aesthetic theory, its living use of folk-theatre traditions and its concept of a collective protagonist. Its partial use of Brechtian distanciation and its political forthrightness testify to its modern character.

Nevertheless, the play cannot be considered free from structural looseness, a lack of psychological depth in its characters, the absence of a clear *nirvahaṇa-sandhi*, and practical difficulties of performance. Even so, the historical significance and cultural contribution of Parmeshwar Kapari's work within Maithili drama are beyond dispute.

Conclusion and Long-Term Cultural Influence

Parmeshwar Kapari's *Gahan Ugarās* is more than an experimental play of the Maithili stage: it is a practical meeting ground for major theories of contemporary world theatre. Enriched by the indigenous vitality of India's Theatre of Roots, it readily incorporates Brechtian intellectual distance and the fluidity of the Chinese *xieyi* style. Like Yiddish theatre, it brings the inward pain of displacement and the popular power of *shund* into the centre of a literary movement.

Through his wealth of vocabulary and intimate knowledge of folk life, Kapari has created a theatre that strikes, at the regional level, at the contradictions of Nepal's Madhesh movement and people's war, while at the global level offering a new path towards liberation-consciousness to communities struggling with crises of language and identity. The experimental character of *Gahan Ugarās* will stand as an enduring achievement in the history of Maithili drama.

33. Kedarnath Chaudhary Special Issue: Stories, Personality and Literary Achievement

Abstract

Kedarnath Chaudhary Special Issue—Editorial by Gajendra Thakur. I was on night duty. At two in the morning my telephone began ringing. A colleague of mine, a Tamil speaker, was listening to my conversation. When the call ended, he asked in Hindi: “What language were you speaking for an hour? It is such a sweet language.”

Keywords: Kedarnath · Chaudhary · special issue · personality · literary achievement · Kumar · also

Kedarnath Chaudhary Special Issue: Editorial

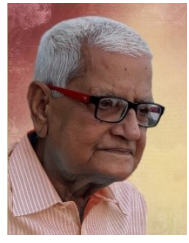
Stories 1–10

I was on night duty. At two in the morning my telephone began ringing. A colleague of mine, a Tamil speaker, was listening to my conversation. When the call ended, he asked in Hindi:

“What language were you speaking for an hour? It is such a sweet language.”

How could I explain to him—or to you—the bitterness concealed within that sweetness? Yet you will have to prepare yourself for it. First comes the starter in Part One; from Part Two onward, the doses will rise to 100, 200 and 500 milligrams, increasing in just that way.

Story 1



Kedarnath Chaudhary (born 1936) was one of the two producers of the first Maithili film, *Mamta Gābay Gīt*; the other was Madanmohan Das.

Udaybhanu Singh subsequently became the third co-producer because of financial difficulties.

Mother: the late Kusumpari Devi. Father: the late Kishori Chaudhary. Date of birth: 3 January 1936.

Village and postal address: Nehra, Darbhanga. Other family members: wife, Mrs Kumud Chaudhary; children, elder daughter Mrs Kiran Jha and younger daughter Mrs Archana Chaudhary. Education: postgraduate degree in Economics, 1958; Law, 1959; postgraduate qualification in Economics from the University of California, 1969; MBA in Marketing and Distribution from Golden Gate University, San Francisco, USA, 1971. Returned to India in 1978. Between 1981 and 1986 he was in Tehran and Frankfurt; subsequently in Bombay and Pune, and, following retirement, resident in Laheriasarai, Darbhanga, from 2000. Six novels: *Chamelirani* (2004), *Karar* (2006), *Mahur* (2008), *Abara Nahitan* (2012), *Hina* (2013) and *Ayana* (2018). Honours: (1) Videha Literary Award, 2013, from the Jharkhand Maithili Manch, Ranchi; (2) Prabodh Literary Award, 2016; and (3) Kedar Award, 2016, for *Abara Nahitan*.

Story 2

Dr Kalpana Manikant Mishra

Her father was Dr Shiv Kumar Jha; her natal village was Rati and her marital home Gajhara. Having completed her medical education at J. J. Hospital/Grant Hospital, she became a gynaecologist. Together with her husband Dr Manikant Mishra, the producer of the Maithili film *Au Piya Hamar Nagari*, she edited the Maithili journal *Videha*, published from Bombay during 1980–82.

In an email from 2009 she writes:

"My greetings to Gajendra Thakurji! I am a regular reader of your magazine. I found the background song on your website moving and melodious."

She continues with a reminiscence, also collected in *Videha Sadeha 2* (http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm):

Mother Tongue

"Much has been written and said about love for one's mother tongue. You too must have heard of it many times, but very few are granted the opportunity to experience it personally. We had only recently arrived in Bombay. More than an age has passed since the incident, yet I cannot bring myself to forget it—and why should I? We were lost in the dazzling metropolis and feared losing our way. In the 1980s a scheme of Sanjay Gandhi's offered unemployed graduates bank loans of Rs 20,000 on favourable terms. I was an unemployed doctor myself. I applied and received the loan immediately. But what was I to do with the money? I could have invested in my profession: a dispensary or a small house in which I might later open a clinic. All that was quite accessible and possible then, though today it would be a dream at that price. By investing the money I could have secured my future, bought jewellery and ornaments to satisfy my wishes, or travelled throughout India. But no! My husband, Dr Manikant Mishra, wished to launch a magazine in Maithili. Together we started a Maithili periodical called *Videha*. The magazine was printed, certainly, but who would buy it and who would read it? That was the great problem. Somehow, investing our household savings, we kept it going for two years. Then we had to close it. Both of us practised medicine, and managing home, hospital and family responsibilities was very difficult. We were newcomers to Bombay. No ordinary person would have dared such an undertaking; only Dr Manikant Mishra could do it, because of his passionate attachment to Maithili. Neither Bombay's frantic life nor the ups and downs of his health diminished his devotion to the language."

"...And twenty or twenty-two years later, he committed all his money and the whole strength of his body to making the Maithili film *Au Piya Hamar Nagari*. It was a beautiful film; perhaps you have seen it. If not, please watch it at least once. I cannot now describe the hardships and experiences of making it. Perhaps another time...! But amid these events, Mother Maithili was parted forever from her worthy son. Is there any devoted son of his mother tongue who can feel Mother Maithili's heartache and dedicate everything to her?"

Story 3

Greetings on 15 August 2022, India's seventy-sixth Independence Day. It was a coincidence that *Videha*'s sixty-fourth issue had been published electronically on 15 August 2010, twelve years earlier, on the country's sixty-fourth Independence Day. This time its 352nd issue has just appeared online.

My father died in 1995, aged fifty-five. Twelve years ago, however, his friends and elders from the village were still alive. When the sisters of

Parashuramji and Dhaneshwarji went to Jhanjharpur to study with Mallikji, wealthy local people ostracised them. Parashuramji's sister's studies were interrupted. Dhaneshwarji, who was somewhat older, held his ground. The British police were made to arrest him, and the person who had arranged his arrest later continued receiving a freedom-fighter's pension. In 1942 Dhaneshwarji and his companions drove the British police out of the police station and installed Phekan Munshi as its officer in charge. I recall my father's words: a wealthy former MLA from the village refused to sign his scholarship form. Nevertheless, he obtained admission to engineering at MIT Muzaffarpur in 1959, with roll number one and the highest marks.

On one occasion Dhaneshwarji, Parashuramji and my father went to eat at Gopeshji's house. It was a protest against the ostracism led by wealthy people after Gopeshji had eaten eggs. Dhaneshwarji and Gopeshji are no longer with us, and Parashuramji too died this year. After retiring in 1998 from a professorship of English in Kolkata, Parashuramji wrote two English books on "English Poetics". In my book *Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind*, the dedication reads:

"I had seen my father bear truth with a mind steadfast and undisturbed;

It was then that I understood

That renunciation might not have been made;

The path is to be obstinately resolute.

—Dedicated to all the fond and bitter memories of my father."

Reading it, he held both my cheeks in his hands and could not restrain his tears. Many villagers wept on reading the dedication, saying that it was all the fruit of my father's merit. I do not know why these memories returned again on Independence Day.

Story 4

The Sahitya Akademi Award Controversy

Paghalait Himakhand is a collection of poems translated by Dr Shiv Kumar Prasad from Rajni Chhabra's Hindi original *Pighalte Himkhand*. It reached the final round—and lost there. We shall see what happens next year. It appeared serially online in *Videha* and was later published as a book. The poems were collected in *Videha Sadeha 28*, available for download at http://www.videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm. The writer belongs not to what I call the "washed-dhoti" tradition, but to the "plain-dhoti" tradition. This time, for the first time, the main award went to a novelist of that plain-dhoti tradition, Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal, for his novel *Pangu*; it was unprecedented in the history of the Sahitya Akademi.

The prize had seemed reserved for those in washed dhotis. *Pangu* appeared serially online in *Videha* and then as a book, and was collected in *Videha Sadeha 21*, downloadable from the same link. The Sahitya Akademi Tagore Literature Award for Maithili in 2011 had also been given to Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal for his short-story collection *Gamak Jingi*. The ceremony took place in Kochi on 12 June 2012. There seems little chance of Maithili's controversies ending. Even then, when referees forwarded seven names for the 2011 Tagore Literature Award in Maithili, one book had not even been published within the stipulated 2007–09 period. Was it recommended without being examined? Did the Sahitya Akademi identify the person who recommended it? Was that person's name made public? Was the person permanently barred? None of this happened. How, then, can Maithili's standing be preserved?

The award should also have gone to Shiv Kumar Prasad, but two people from the plain-dhoti tradition could not be honoured in the same year. Even a single award to someone in a plain dhoti has provoked an uproar among washed-dhoti wearers from both forward and backward communities and among those I call "mixed-varna" litterateurs (the term has nothing whatever to do with biological mixture of varnas).

Those wearing washed dhotis should relinquish the translation assignments they distribute among themselves through the Sahitya Akademi. Those assignments ought instead to be offered to Nand Vilas Rai, Rajdev Mandal, Rambillas Sahu, Dhirendra Kumar, Durganand Mandal, Manoj Kumar Mandal, Shiv Kumar Prasad, Umesh Paswan, Sandeep Kumar Safi, Bechan Thakur, Meghan Prasad, Kishan Karigar, Laldev Mahto, Umesh Mandal, Shardanand Singh, Subhash Kumar Kamat, Munni Kamat and others. That would create an army of *Agniveers* for Maithili. Meghan Prasad expressed this wish in an article in *Videha*, yet he was not offered a translation assignment. Half-congratulations to Ashok Avichal: during his tenure only one person in a plain dhoti, not two, managed to receive an award. What new pretexts the magicians of the washed-dhoti factions, both forward and backward, will devise, and whether the Sahitya Akademi will once more become the exclusive preserve of washed-dhoti wearers next year—only the future can tell.

Story 5

A Literary Event

I shall recount a literary event. It occurred in the modern period of Tamil literature.

The mainstream summoned scholars from across the world and staged an enormous array of programmes and publicity. Writers of quite extraordinary stature were invited, event followed event, and the radio and

television were full of promotion. The mainstream threw money about. The grand number-one programme came to an end.

What did the parallel current do? It published an anthology of contemporary alternative prose and poetry called *Kurukshetram*. Produced on ordinary paper with a plain design, this *Kurukshetram* shook Tamil literature. A debate began over which of two simultaneous events had contributed more to the history of Tamil literature: the money-squandering world—or perhaps universe—conference of Tamil literature, or *Kurukshetram*.

The majority held that the modestly printed and designed *Kurukshetram* was the more significant event.

Videha's special issues devoted to living writers have become the *Kurukshetram* of Maithili literature. In Facebook debates writers have acknowledged that these special issues have gained greater importance than the Sahitya Akademi Award. The clamour surrounding the Akademi, despite the lakhs of rupees at stake, shows no sign of dying down. The mainstream has become entangled in its own net: those who received assignments clamour for awards, those who received awards struggle for assignments, and those who received neither demand both. Those who have received both are in the worst situation: neither does the Akademi properly recognise them nor can their writing stand before the parallel current. A few exceptions have fallen into depression or begun declaring themselves marginalised, indeed members of the parallel current.

In other words, proclaiming oneself marginalised or part of the parallel current has become a fashion among mainstream writers, whether of forward or backward communities (the writers of towering stature in both belong to the mainstream). But it is not, in fact, a fashion...

Story 6

How Does One Become a Scholar?

"Maithili was the language of Sita, mother of the universe"—"Hanuman said: *mānuṣīm iha saṃskṛtām*."

A Pillar of Letters (*akkhar / akṣara*)

"In the field of the three worlds, how shall his creeper of fame spread if, erecting pillars of letters, he does not raise the platform?" [Verse retained from *Kīrtilatā*: *tihuan khettahi kāñi tasu kittivalli pasarei / akkhar khambhārambha jau mañco bandhi na dei*.]

[The first couplet of the first *pallava* of *Kīrtilatā*.] That is, if one does not build pillars made of letters and upon them erect the stage of poetry, how can the creeper of one's fame spread across the field of the three worlds?

You will have seen people in villages who make telling use of Sanskrit maxims. Before *Videha* appeared in Maithili literature, a writer who could recite ten such maxims from memory qualified as a scholar. Bashō too rightly said that whoever had composed three to five haiku in a lifetime was a haiku poet, and someone who had composed ten was a great poet.

Here are thirty-two selected Sanskrit maxims. Memorise just ten and you too will be a mighty scholar by the standards of Maithili's mainstream. But where is that shortcut in the parallel current? There will be nobody here to flatter you; you will have to work hard.

Subhāṣitam ("Well-spoken words": a maxim)

Learning protects like a mother, directs one towards one's good like a father, and, like a beloved, delights and drives away distress.

It increases prosperity and spreads fame to every quarter. Like a wish-fulfilling creeper, what can learning not accomplish?

What can scripture do for someone who possesses no understanding of their own?

What use is a mirror to a person without eyes?

Who in this world does not live for their own sake?

It is the person who lives for the good of others who truly lives.

An ant that keeps walking can travel even hundreds of *yojanas*;

Even Garuḍa, if he does not move, cannot advance a single step.

Straw for seating, the earth, water, and, fourth, gracious speech:

Even these are never lacking in the home of a good person.

People who invariably say agreeable things are easy to find in this world;

Rare are the speakers—and listeners—of truths that are unpleasant but beneficial.

The single safeguard of acquired wealth is giving it away;

Just as the water held within a pond is kept wholesome by its outflow. [The source verse is textually irregular.]

Knowledge confined to books and money held in another person's hands —

When the moment of need arrives, neither that knowledge nor that wealth is of use.

The union of many things, each with little strength, can accomplish a task;

Twisted into ropes, blades of grass can bind even an enraged elephant.

A pot gradually fills with the falling of single drops of water;

This is the principle behind the accumulation of knowledge, merit, and wealth.

One should consider beforehand what to do when disaster strikes;

It is no use beginning to dig a well once the house is burning.

Regard other people's wives as mothers, and their possessions as mere clods of earth;

Whoever regards all beings as oneself is a learned person.

One whose plans and counsels are not known to outsiders,

And whose deeds alone become known when accomplished, is called wise by everyone.

One whose heart is compassionate and whose speech is adorned with truth,

And whose body labours for others—what can the age of Kali do to such a person?

People imitate one another; they do not always pursue ultimate truth.

"Because of a sand-made *liṅga* beside the Ganges, my copper vessel disappeared." [A satirical maxim about unthinking imitation.]

The hand is adorned by generosity, not bracelets; purity comes from bathing, not sandalwood paste.

Fulfilment comes from honour, not food; liberation from knowledge, not a shaved head.

A student receives one quarter of learning from the teacher, and another through personal intelligence;

A third from fellow students, and the fourth through the passage of time.

As the mind is, so are the words; as the words are, so are the deeds;

In great people there is unity of thought, speech, and action.

No syllable is without the possibility of a mantra; no root is without medicinal potential;

No person is inherently useless; what is rare is someone who can put each to the right use.

One who weighs merit and defect in what lies ahead, decides promptly in the present,

And understands what remains from the past is not overwhelmed by misfortune.

Do not grieve over what is past, nor be anxious about the future;

The discerning attend to the present moment.

Trees give others shade while standing in the scorching sun themselves;

Their fruits too are offered to others: trees are like good people.

What is remarkable about treating a benefactor well?

One who treats even an enemy well is rightly praised as good.

Work is accomplished through effort, not wishes;

Deer do not walk into the mouth of a sleeping lion.

"This one is mine, that one a stranger"—such calculation belongs to narrow minds;

For the generous in spirit, the whole world is one family.

All living creatures are pleased by kindly words;

So speak kindly: what poverty is there in words?

No consecration or rite is performed to crown the lion in the forest;

By its own strength and prowess it becomes king of beasts.

Harder than a thunderbolt, softer than flowers—

Who can fathom the hearts of extraordinary people?

The gift of food is a noble gift, but the gift of knowledge is greater;

Food satisfies for a moment; learning sustains one for a lifetime.

Six defects must be abandoned by anyone who seeks prosperity:

Excessive sleep, torpor, fear, anger, laziness, and procrastination.

Without causing others pain, without stooping to the wicked,

And without abandoning the path of the good, even a small achievement is great.

A country with a vast expanse of land and a population too numerous to reach,

If deprived of organisation, cannot protect itself.

Story 7

Now, a Few Pieces of Advice

At the request of my friends, I am setting down here some of the advice I often offer them in conversation.

Always drink low-fat milk and eat less salt. Reduce your consumption of meat, though you can eat more fish. Pay attention to the daily routines of people in your neighbourhood; otherwise change your home. Praise people, for your appreciation will greatly encourage them. Cook a vegetable dish or another delicacy for a neighbour and write down the recipe for them as well. Harbour neither malice nor prejudice against anyone. When visiting a shopping mall, park the car far away and walk there with your family and children. Do not watch violent television serials; boycott the products of the companies sponsoring them. Respect all people, animals, and birds. If you borrow someone's vehicle, return it with the petrol or diesel tank completely full. People usually do the reverse: they borrow a car with fuel and bring it back on reserve. You will see the owner speak well of you for days and never make excuses about lending it to you again. Greet five or seven people every day. Keep one or two domestic animals; if you live in Delhi or Mumbai, raise a dog instead. At least once a month watch the sunrise—and watch the stars too. Remember other people's names and birthdays. Always tip the person serving your food in a hotel. Greet people warmly when you meet them, shake hands, and always look them in the eye while speaking. Use words of thanks and respect. Be sure to learn a musical instrument; if nothing else, you can surely play the *jhāl* cymbals. Sing while bathing.

Measure your success by the service you render to others, not by things you acquire at someone else's expense. Deceiving others is wrong; being deceived is not. Learn how to conduct an interview and what its essential points are. Listen to rumours but do not embellish or contribute to their circulation. Attend to your children's worries and fears. Do not quarrel with your mother. Do not believe everything you hear. Save something from the money you have before spending it. Treat elderly people courteously. Never tolerate evil or injustice. Preserve letters of appreciation. Distribute the printed text of a seminar address only after you have delivered it. Begin saving for your children's education as soon as you marry. Parents should always teach their children independence. You can become mentally independent only when you stop waiting for others to solve your problems. Marriage and bringing up children are not such

burdensome matters. Smiling makes you look beautiful: laugh heartily. Unless you undertake new things, how will you learn new things? If you insist on doing a task without a single mistake, that task may never be completed. Even after a long interval, try to repair a damaged relationship. Human feeling can help us accomplish a task and overcome even the hardest circumstances. You learn about a path, an idea or an undertaking by advancing along it, not merely by arguing about it. A friend is someone who knows all your virtues and failings and likes you nonetheless.

Always share your knowledge and experience, and remain modest in speech, action and judgement. When someone speaks well of a friend of yours, let that friend know. If you believe an action is right, do it. Do not work merely to establish a reputation; do work that people can recognise and remember. The great changes of life arrive without warning. Teach children not to undervalue another person because of their limitations. Whatever you do, do with your whole heart. Always be among the first to applaud at the end of a play. Think, believe in your idea, dream, and have the courage to realise your dream.

Story 8

I now present a review written in 2008–09, published electronically in *Videha* and later included in my book *Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind* (2009).

Kedarnath Chaudhary's Novels *Chamelirani* and *Mahur*

Kedarnath Chaudhary's first novel, *Chamelirani*, appeared in 2004. It ended so attractively that readers clamoured for a second part, prompting the novelist to write *Mahur*. Reviewing *Chamelirani* in *Vidyapati Times*, Dhirendranath Mishra wrote: "Just as the emperor of humour Harimohan Babu had to write *Dviragaman* after *Kanyadan*, this novelist too will have to write a second part to *Chamelirani*." Both volumes will be remembered in Maithili fiction for several reasons. As Ramlochan Thakur asks, "Why was the arrival of this writer with his touchstone-like talent so long delayed?" That question truly remains unanswered. With his considerable energies, Chaudhary pursued education and employment in America, Iran and elsewhere. But when the producer of *Mamta Gābay Gīt* returned to Darbhanga, he poured the experiences of his whole life into these two novels. I once asked Rajmohan Jha about this in an interview, and he said writing is impossible without lived experience; the broader a writer's experience, the greater the variety and novelty that writer can bring. *Chamelirani* and *Mahur* prove the point. *Chamelirani* established a new sales record: five hundred copies were sold in Janakpur alone. The author dedicated it "To every lover of Maithili who has spent even a penny of their own money during their entire life to buy a Maithili book or

periodical." But its extraordinary sales obliged him to issue a second edition in 2007, before *Mahur* appeared in 2008. For the second volume he evidently thought it better to omit the dedication. I noticed another distinctive feature late in 2008, when Haryana's deputy chief minister disappeared for a month. Diplomatic and political compulsions made it impossible to take action against him until his return. Our Gulab Mishra likewise remained in office despite disappearing, because of the same political compulsion; nobody could remove him, whatever difficulties that created for the government.

The novelist's life experience had enabled him to imagine such a possibility four years in advance. Prophecy does not spring from sorcery: lived experience makes such anticipation possible.

The characters in both novels are remarkable—and successful—because the novelist creates them as though he has known everything about them from personal experience.

At the opening of *Chamelirani*, the author passes his first test: a rhythmic beginning awakens the reader's interest. When Kirtimukh's close friend Kantir suggests names for Kirtimukh's five sons, he says: "Give the five sons the names of the five Pandavas. It will be convenient." Elsewhere the writer observes that, had children continued to arrive at the same speed, names from the Kauravas would have been needed. Until the heroine Chamelirani arrives, Kirtimukh's sons are described. Then come the Englishman Demsford and Rupkummari's daughter Sunayana; Sunayana's daughter Shanichari; and Shanichari's marriage to the political leader Ramthenga Singh "Chingari". The leader, fearing public disgrace, leaves Shanichari in Kanhi Modiyani's care and goes to Patna. His death, followed by Shanichari's marriage to Kirtimukh, draws these strands of the story together again.

The narrative then introduces Chamelirani, a boarding-school student at the school attached to the Barauni refinery and the daughter of Kanhi Modiyani. By the time Kanhi Modiyani dies, Chamelirani has passed her tenth-standard examination. Bhukhan Singh is her adoptive or religious father. The first part closes with an account of a robbery.

The second part recounts a previously planned robbery of an MLA's money or treasure, represented as the consequence of the rape of a modern young woman by MLA Nangtanath. Nangtanath, formerly an attendant of Chief Minister Gulab Misir, had made his way into the legislature through political manoeuvring.

This character closely resembles Balram Halwai in Aravind Adiga's Booker Prize-winning English novel of 2008, *The White Tiger*: a boy working in a tea stall becomes the driver of a wealthy Delhi man, murders him and

makes himself rich. Yet Chaudhary had conceived his character four years earlier. Then enters the KGB agent Bhataji, whose presence remains strikingly effective through the second volume, *Mahur*.

In the third part, Ahmadullah Khan's operation is equally absorbing and draws together the ugliness of contemporary politics. The fourth part recounts Gulab Misir's tale and once again recalls Adiga's Balram Halwai. Gulab Misir summons Panna, a friend of Bhukhan Singh, and tells him about Bhukhan Singh's actions against Nangtanath and Ahmadullah. He orders Panna to kill him; Panna refuses. Gulab Misir nevertheless has Bhukhan Singh killed by deception.

The fifth part concerns Bhukhan Singh's trust. Chamelirani leaves her base and travels to Baidyanath Dham. Her political ambitions now come into view. A sting operation traps Gulab Misir.

The sixth part discusses how, even after the chief minister's disappearance, only a fact-finding committee is constituted—an observation on the compulsions of coalition politics.

The first part of the second volume, *Mahur*, circles back to the organisation of Chamelirani's party. The novelist uses organisations that oppress women, perpetuate child widowhood, and push women into prostitution as subjects of commentary.

The second part of *Mahur* describes Gulab Misir's arrival in the capital. Chamelirani visits a Naxalite leader's hideout to seek support for her campaign. The author uses the occasion to present his views on the entire Naxalite movement; his vivid account of forest life and Adivasi communities demonstrates his skill. Chamelirani learns another secret: her mother, Kanhi Modiyani, came from a very prominent family; Patel had subjected her to atrocities, her father had been murdered, and the unfortunate woman had survived by living as Kanhi Modiyani. These revelations deepen the novel's fascination.

The third part again generates mystery and suspense amid the conspiracies of Pachkauri Miyan, Gulab Misir, the ISI and the KGB.

The fourth part of *Mahur* describes Chamelirani avenging the atrocities inflicted on her parents. She becomes wealthy after acquiring property worth thousands of crores.

The fifth part ends with political manoeuvring and the victory of Chamelirani's party.

Critical Discussion: Despite the bourgeois origins of the novel as a genre, it has acquired such complexity that it thoroughly tests a writer's talent. Although Cervantes's *Don Quixote* appeared at the beginning of the

seventeenth century, the genre did not attain a fully serious form until shortly before the nineteenth. Debate and dialogue in the novel produce the essayistic element; young men and women's characters bring romance; people and geography supply historical description; then come stories of good and bad characters. Sometimes the novel makes readers laugh, sometimes it instructs them. Marxism argues for the novel's social realism. Freud sees human beings as mysterious and selects literary works as instruments for analysing their authors, whereas neo-Freudianism places greater emphasis on cultural than on biological factors. New Criticism rests on close and detailed engagement with the work. Together with all this, life experience remains one-sided, and the writer here creates a world in which repressed desires can be satisfied, while the reader walks the boundary between reality and imagination.

Story 9

The Saketanand Episode

Saketanand's post of 12 November 2009:

http://saketanands.blogspot.com/2009/11/blog-post_12.html

He writes:

"It seems to me that, just as some politicians begin to fidget the moment they see a crowd, a stage and a microphone, certain writers do the same. Once two or four of their works have been discussed somewhere, they immediately become 'established'. Thereafter, if they glimpse a literary stage, they are ready to seize a chair. Seeing Alok Dhanwa seated with Namvar at the book fair held in Patna, I felt that writing and the politics of literature are opposite poles that cannot coexist. Maithili still has the generosity of its own soil and a touch of the *ayācī* tradition, refusing to solicit favours. Even now, without considering who will publish a text or, more importantly, who will read it, people keep writing, and writing without end."

"In my view, when people find something worth reading—of whatever kind—they will certainly read it."

"So should people now write *Chamelirani*?"

Story 10

This Is Not a Story

Saketanand was a learned man, but wrote out of envy. Harimohan Jha too had to endure such harassment. Neither Harimohan Jha nor Kedarnath Chaudhary was someone who had merely memorised Sanskrit maxims. Harimohan Jha translated Datta and Chatterjee's *An Introduction to*

Indian Philosophy into Hindi, not to win a translation award but to prove himself as a professor of philosophy. He also made his fictional character Khattar Kaka recite Sanskrit verses; the difference is in their use.

People have sacrificed everything for Maithili. Dr Kalpana Manikant Mishra and Kedarnath Chaudhary are only two examples. People fear fraudsters, especially those who freeload in the name of theatre and cinema. Bhramarji's CD was even reissued by others under their own names. Literature is in much the same condition.

If the stories above have shaken you, join the parallel current. If they have not, my efforts will continue, and special issues will continue to appear for that very reason.

34. Kedarnath Chaudhary: A Re-reading of the Writer and His Novel

Abstract

Kedarnath Chaudhary—A Re-reading of the Writer and His Novel. After failing the matriculation examination, the decision to end one's life by jumping from the easily accessible Ekmi Bridge into the Bagmati's furious current could not be shaken even by the fragrance of *jalebi* and *kachauri* fried in pure country ghee. Nevertheless, one resolution was reached: before committing suicide, one would eat a hearty portion of *jalebi-kachauri*. Eat at the restaurant, walk to Ekmi Bridge, and the matter would end. But Khattar Kaka's own younger brother happens to be there.

Keywords: Kedarnath · Chaudhary · re-reading of the novel · chapter · film · none

Kedarnath Chaudhary: A Re-reading of the Writer and His Novel

Having failed the matriculation examination, he resolves to end his life by jumping from Ekmi Bridge, an easily accessible spot, into the Bagmati's raging waters. Even the smell of *jalebi* and *kachauri* fried in pure country ghee cannot dissuade him. Still, he decides to eat a hearty helping of *jalebi-kachauri* before taking his life.

So: eat *jalebi-kachauri* at the restaurant, go to Ekmi Bridge—and that will be the end.

But Khattar Kaka's own younger brother is present there. The background, too, is worth remembering: the incident belongs to a time when the country had already become independent and a republic.

One of the two young men was already married; the event's date is given earlier, and so the question of child marriage and related matters is settled.

Then a friend's maternal uncle arrives. He proposes to arrange employment for his nephew that will enable him to send bundles of money to his father. So the question of suicide vanishes altogether. The nephew leaves for Howrah, while the autobiographical novel's narrator, its "I", leaves for the village. Chapter One ends.

In Chapter Two, our "I" obtains an MA in Economics. Then enters Prabuddha, who has earned a PhD in England. Chapter Two ends. It does not actually end quite so quickly, but given the pace of Chapter One you can guess how the second proceeds. There is a reference to the magazine *Mithila*, with the observation that its paper and type were as rough as a rasp, just like Mithila itself.

Chapter Three begins with earning a living in Calcutta. Chapter Four brings the arrest of Janaki Nandan Singh and an observation attributed to someone with a PhD from England—perhaps not merely perhaps, but indeed Lakshman Jha, the famous Lakhan Jha—about what the people on the ground have said. Our "I" then departs for the residence of Mahant Madan Das. The real drama begins.

Chapter Five concerns work for Maithili, film production for that purpose, and the capital it requires: our "I" will have to resign from his job.

Born in 1936, he is now in 1961, at that age of youthful twenty-five. He resigns. Chapter Six ends.

Chapter Seven: arrival in Bombay.

Chapter Eight: Parmanand Chaudhary, in a distinctly cinematic style. The debate now turns to whether the film's story should be mythological or social.

Chapter Nine: the screenplay is ready. Rabindra becomes the lyricist. Who will sing the songs? Lata and Rafi charge Rs 3,000 for each song. Suman Kalyanpur accepts Rs 1,400 for two songs, while her husband issues a receipt for Rs 300. Geeta Dutt is continually intoxicated, troubled by difficulties with her husband Guru Dutt, who later takes his own life; she records her song in five days. Music costs Rs 14,000 in all. Phanishwar Nath Renu is deeply moved by news that a Maithili film is being made.

Chapter Ten: shooting at Rajnagar.

Chapter Eleven: filming ends after two months and thirteen days. Carrying the film negatives in twenty aluminium boxes, "I" and Madan Bhai leave for Bombay.

Chapter Twelve: panic follows the news that only a little more than half the film has actually been made.

Chapter Thirteen: they reach Calcutta with five edited reels. A screening at Ganesh Talkies takes place, and the song "Bhar nagari me sor, bauā māmī tohar gor" ("The whole town is abuzz, little one: your aunt is fair") moves everyone deeply.

Chapter Fourteen: our "I" is selected for admission to an American university.

Chapter Fifteen: he returns to India in 1977. Rabindranath Thakur acquires the rights from Kedarnath Chaudhary and has the film completed and released, earning a handsome profit.

One thing this book does not mention is that the film was also shown on Doordarshan several times.

By now you must have realised that this is no conventional novel: it carries no disclaimer that its places and characters are fictional. Yet how did its ending become as poignant as that of Harimohan Jha's *Graduate Putohu*? And what, after all, is a novel? Everyone's life is a novel. Let everyone write an autobiography and novels will keep coming into being.

This is a book written in an autobiographical manner. Its "I" is Kedarnath Chaudhary. It tells the story of why people flee even from the road on which programmes are organised in the name of Maithili and Mithila.

That is why I regard all of Kedarnath Chaudhary's writing as compulsory reading for candidates preparing for competitive examinations. Even children's fathers would be unable to stage the Maithili translation of Rabindranath Tagore's children's play published by the Sahitya Akademi. I cannot accept the argument that whatever is being done by theatrical, literary and Mithila-activist institutions must therefore be right.

The novel belongs to the autobiographical and memoiristic categories.

If you can "shoot" your own life, you will discover that life seen through the lens has greater impact. A stage actor moving into cinema may not need glycerine to bring tears to their eyes. You may think that if you film yourself driving along an empty road in the rain, the lens will transform you into a "film hero". I refuse to give that illusion any importance. I believe not only examination candidates but literary writers too should read these books. Indeed I advise everyone to take a summer course in photography. Here is another suggestion: mobile phones now have cameras; record five or ten minutes of video every day. Look at the world through square, rectangular, triangular and other frames, and experience how even the weightiest subject can be made intelligible. The physicist Feynman, of *The Feynman Lectures*, is celebrated for teaching physics engagingly. Yet here we have remarkable worthies who write even "fiction" as though it were "physics".

Why do people not watch art films? Because writers and directors imagine that merely choosing an art-film subject will win them prizes. In reality, art films can also become hits. *The Kashmir Files*, though a documentary-style film, succeeded because its director and scriptwriter were not dishonest. When the Polish people in *Schindler's List* say, "Go, Jew, go," does that make the film one-sided? Must we now introduce a good Polish person into the script to correct it? Neither can everything fit into a 180-minute film (100 minutes abroad), nor into a memoir of one hundred or one hundred and twenty-five pages. Someone may object that Kedarnath Chaudhary abandoned the film and Rabindranath Thakur completed it. But that is precisely what the book itself says.

Plain language requires greater talent. In this small book we meet campaigners for Mithila whom everyone respects—but that is as far as it goes. We also encounter the condition of Maithili institutions. Should people therefore abandon the undertaking like gamblers leaving the table? No. Instead, look at yourself within the frame and ask what work you were made to do.

The sharpness of Kedarnath Chaudhary's pen does not arise from talent alone. It also comes from what he experienced in Bombay, and from the art of "shooting" and "editing" frames that he learned and observed there. That art appears in all his writing. Many people go on "shooting" indefinitely but lose their sense of how much to "edit".

His work has an edge in both senses: the edge that cuts and the current that flows. That is how a memoir has become a novel.

Appendix: Shailendra Mohan Jha's composition, collected in *Videha Sadeha 32* (available at http://videha.co.in/new_page_89.htm). Notice how *Mamta Gābay Gīt* has become a legend among the younger generation and entered a song.

Shailendra Mohan Jha

I am fortunate to belong to Bharwara, the village of Gonu Jha, whom the whole of India knows as a supreme master of humour. I presently work as a manager with Tata Motors Finance Limited in Sambalpur.

A Dream

I lay asleep one afternoon and saw a dream;
Sister-in-law, I was married—my bride was lovely as the moon.
My dream broke, dear sister-in-law, in the middle of the afternoon...

When I met her I was overjoyed;
Seeing her beauty, sister-in-law, I was astonished.
I asked her name, and she said it was Rajni;
That dream-beauty became the queen of my heart.

She asked me, "Tell me, beloved, how do I look?"
I said, "Listen, my darling, you look like the moon.
Yet even the moon has blemishes, while you are spotless.
Your eyes are like Aishwarya's, your nose like Juhi Chawla's;
Your hair is like Neelam's, your cheeks like Vyjayanthimala's."

Then I asked, "And how do I look?"
She said, "Not so good; well, you are just about all right.

But, darling, why have you become so bald while still young?"
"You resemble Sunny a little, and Rahul Roy somewhat;
And there is something of Govinda in you too—that is my opinion."

Then I said, "Come, my beloved, let us go sightseeing in Darbhanga.
I shall buy a sari for you, and an aṅgā *garment for myself.*
I have two tickets for Uma Talkies, seats side by side;
Together we will watch Mamta Gābay Gīt."
I took her hand in mine and rose to depart;
I took her hand in mine and rose to depart;
Just then Pintua woke me—just then Pintua woke me, and I rose from sleep.
My dream was broken, dear sister-in-law, in the middle of the afternoon...

My hair has become rather sparse.
The title of a well-known Maithili film.
*Pintua is my younger brother.

35. The Sahitya Akademi Awards Controversy: Yuva and Bal Awards, 2022

Abstract

The Sahitya Akademi Awards controversy (Yuva and Bal Awards, 2022): There seems no prospect of the controversies surrounding Maithili coming to an end. *Antataḥ* ("At Last"), the poetry collection by Munni Kamat, reached the final round and lost there—or was made to lose. Some of Munni Kamat's books are available for download at http://www.videha.co.in/archive.htm.

Keywords: Akademi · awards · controversy · youth · 2022 · Shri · Mandal

The Sahitya Akademi Awards Controversy (Yuva and Bal Awards, 2022): There seems no prospect of the controversies surrounding Maithili coming to an end.

1

The Yuva Puraskar Controversy

Antataḥ, Munni Kamat's collection of poems, reached the final round and lost—or was made to lose. Let us see what happens next year. Some of Munni Kamat's books can be downloaded from http://www.videha.co.in/archive.htm. The author belongs not to the "washed-dhoti-and-sari" tradition, but to the "plain-dhoti-and-sari" tradition. Her writing contains genuine feminist questioning, as well as subjects the mainstream has not yet even thought to address—for example, the use of poor people as test subjects or "vectors" in drug trials, and their deaths. Be that as it may...

2

The Bal Sahitya Puraskar Controversy

Discussion of this is futile. The shortlisted books all came from people in immaculate, dazzlingly white washed dhotis and saris—those "farmhouse-chicken" types. People of the plain-dhoti tradition had also published books, but for children, not for juries. Who prepared the preliminary list? Will their names be made public? Will they be permanently barred? If not, how is Maithili's reputation to survive?

This year, for the first time, the principal award was given to a novelist from the plain-dhoti tradition, Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal, for his novel *Pangu*. It was the first such event in the history of the Sahitya Akademi. The award had seemed reserved for the washed-dhoti circle. The novel was

published serially online in *Videha* before appearing as a book, and was collected in *Videha Sadeha 21*, available for download at http://www.videha.co.in/archive.htm.

The Yuva award should also have gone to Munni Kamat, and a translation award to Shiv Kumar Prasad, but it would apparently be impossible to honour two or three plain-dhoti-and-sari writers in the same year. Even the recognition of one plain-dhoti writer has provoked an uproar among washed-dhoti wearers of both forward and backward communities and among those whom I call "mixed-varna" litterateurs (this has nothing to do with biological mixture of varnas). But two from the plain-dhoti tradition cannot, it seems, be honoured in the same year. Recognition of just one has already stirred the same uproar among washed-dhoti wearers of both forward and backward communities and among the "mixed-varna" litterateurs (again, the term has no biological connotation).

Shri Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Shri Rajdev Mandal and Shri Bechan Thakur —respectively, in my view, the greatest living Maithili novelist and storyteller, poet, and dramatist—along with Shri Umesh Paswan, Shri Umesh Mandal, Shri Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jharudar", and Shri Durganand Mandal: are there no assignments for any of them? But can an alleged conspiracy by the Maithili Advisory Board to destroy Maithili actually kill the language? No. Why not? Because Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdev Mandal, Bechan Thakur, Umesh Paswan, Umesh Mandal, Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jharudar", Durganand Mandal and many others are nourishing its roots with their own body, mind and money—with their sweat and blood. This alleged conspiracy to kill Maithili will not succeed. The language will live.

Every member of the advisory committee should immediately return or cause the return of their assignments—"their own" meaning those taken for themselves, their families, children or protégés. Otherwise they should face pressure to resign. *Aṣṭajāma* devotional singing should take place before their homes; the national song should be sung, and an *aṣṭajāma* of the national song held.

If a Mithila state were created under these circumstances, those same ten families would consume it entirely.

The organisations campaigning for Mithila statehood should burn these spurious translations at their meetings. Only then could they show whether they intend to create a state of Mithila or merely a state of Maithili.

Those in washed dhotis should give up the Sahitya Akademi translation assignments they pass among themselves. The assignments should be given to Nand Vilas Rai, Rajdev Mandal, Rambillas Sahu, Dhirendra Kumar,

Durganand Mandal, Manoj Kumar Mandal, Shiv Kumar Prasad, Umesh Paswan, Sandeep Kumar Safi, Bechan Thakur, Meghan Prasad, Kishan Karigar, Laldev Mahto, Umesh Mandal, Shardanand Singh, Subhash Kumar Kamat, Munni Kamat and others, thus creating an army of *Agniveers* for Maithili. Meghan Prasad expressed that wish in *Videha*, yet did not receive an assignment. One-third congratulations to Ashok Avichal: during his tenure only one plain-dhoti writer, rather than three plain-dhoti-and-sari writers, received an award. What excuses the wily washed-dhoti factions of both forward and backward groups will produce, and whether next year the Sahitya Akademi will again become an all-washed-dhoti preserve, remains hidden in the womb of the future.

PART III — LITERARY CRITICISM

Poetry, Songs, Metre and the Reading of Verse

36. The Forgotten Poet: Pandit Ramji Chaudhary (1878–1952)

Abstract

Pandit Ramji Chaudhary (1878–1952) was born in Rudrapur village, Andhratharhi police-station area, Madhubani district. His ancestral origin was Pagulbar Raje, of the Shandilya gotra. In the family genealogy, Jivan Chaudhary, born in Panchobh, Darbhanga, came to Rudrapur in 1801. He had two sons: Shri Rangi Chaudhary and Shri Kant Chaudhary, both born in Rudrapur.

Keywords: forgotten · poet · Pandit · Ramji · Chaudhary · 1878 · 1952 · literary criticism

Pandit Ramji Chaudhary (1878–1952) was born in Rudrapur village, Andhratharhi police-station area, Madhubani district. His ancestral origin was Pagulbar Raje, of the Shandilya gotra.

Genealogy: Jivan Chaudhary, born in Panchobh, Darbhanga, came to Rudrapur in 1801.

—His two sons were Shri Rangi Chaudhary (born in Rudrapur) and Shri Kant Chaudhary (born in Rudrapur).

—Kant Chaudhary had three sons: Shri Chumman Chaudhary, Shri Budhan Chaudhary and Shri Rudan Chaudhary.

—Chumman Chaudhary had two sons: Shri Goni Chaudhary and the poet Pandit Ramji Chaudhary.

Shri Jivan Chaudhary was the poet's great-grandfather. His maternal relatives lived in Rudrapur; that was why he left Panchobh in 1801 and settled in Rudrapur.

The poet's grandfather was an accomplished singer. His chief repertoire consisted of devotional songs addressed to the divine couple Sita and Rama, and this deeply influenced the poet. It was for this reason that he named his grandson Ramji. True to his name, the late poet had memorised Tulsidas's Shri Ramcharitmanas. He answered every question with a chaupai from the Ramayana. The most sorrowful circumstance of his life was that he married three times, yet none of his wives lived longer than four years after marriage. He married for the last time at the age of fifty-three. That wife died within fifteen days of giving birth to a son, Durganath Chaudhary (Dukhiya Chaudhary).

During his lifetime the poet served as a senior raiyat under the Darbhanga Raj. After the death of his third wife he resigned even from that position and devoted himself to worship. His sole published book and his unpublished manuscript contain poetry in Brajabuli as well as Maithili.

These poems bear the imprint of the poet's grandfather's knowledge of ragas; they also include Mithila's Maheshvani songs, Chait-month thumris and morning devotional songs, known as prabhati or parati.

Just as Shankardev composed in Maithili rather than Assamese, Ramji Chaudhary composed in Brajabuli as well as Maithili. Each of his poems identifies a raga, as do the Vidyapati lyrics recovered from Nepal. This influence seems to have come from his grandfather, himself a singer. The people of Mithila worship five deities, yet a Shiva shrine will be found in every village; accordingly, Ramji Chaudhary composed Maheshvani songs, thumris for the month of Chait, and morning hymns (parati or prabhati). The ragas and song forms named in his works are:

1. Raga Rekhta; 2. Lavani; 3. Raga Jhaptala; 4. Raga Dhrupad; 5. Raga Sangeet; 6. Raga Desh; 7. Raga Gauri; 8. Tirhut; 9. Bhajan Vinay; 10. Bhajan Bhairavi; 11. Bhajan Ghazal; 12. Holi; 13. Raga Shyam Kalyan; 14. Kavita; 15. Damphak Holi; 16. Raga Kagu Kafi; 17. Raga Vihag; 18. Ghazal Thumri; 19. Raga Pavas Chaumasa; 20. Bhajan Prabhati; 21. Maheshvani; and 22. Bhajan Kirtan.

His compositions are presented below. All the Maithili verses are reproduced here from his only published book and from a manuscript which the poet had Shri Harekant Chaudhary (now deceased) write out, and which was obtained through Shri Shrimohan Chaudhary.

Various Devotional Songs

Salutations to Shri Ganesha.

1. Prayer

Victory to Ganesha, fair son of Shankara, exceedingly gracious to the helpless;

Protector, round-bellied and wondrously formed, elephant-faced: even the thousand-faced one could not recount your glory.

I am utterly ignorant, I know nothing; grant my heart meditation upon your lotus feet.

Hear something of Ramji's petition: he longs to describe the virtues of Rama.

2. Raga Dhrupad

O mind, serve most gracious Shankara, merciful destroyer of his servants' sorrows;

The Ganga adorns his matted hair; ash covers his body, and a garland of skulls rests upon his breast.

A serpent is his sacred thread, his eyes are vast; drinking vijaya, he wanders in rapture.

The trident is in his hand, a tiger skin his raiment; he keeps alive his servant's hope, O divine lord.

He dwells on Kailash with Girija beside him; the rhythm resounds, the moon shines upon his brow.

Lord of Kashi, your glory is boundless; hearing of it, I hurried to your door.

Look kindly upon poor Ramji; let me swiftly encounter the lord of Ayodhya.

3. Raga Sangeet

The Lord himself dances.

On every side of the woodland bowers stand lovely, dense trees, adorned with blossoms; flowers seem to blush, celestial trees gleam in the moonlight. (1)

Clappers, the damph and cymbals sound; the gopis fill every direction; peacocks cry and dance, and Radha takes up the mridang. (2)

Flutes and other instruments sound in their own melodies; the thirty-six raginis are sung; all who hear hurry there, while waves rise on the Yamuna. (3)

The three worlds rejoice as they listen again and again; even wind and water seem to stir; Ramji peeps from his household tasks at the marvellous spectacle. (4)

4. Tirhut

My beloved has abandoned me in the bloom of youth, dear friend; what can I say of his judgment?

I have not seen him with these eyes, dear friend, though a year or two have passed.

Neither house nor bed brings delight, dear friend; if only he would clasp me fully in his arms.

What shall I do with such a life, dear friend? Others will speak only ill of me.

Fine ornaments and garments mean nothing, dear friend; little life remains in me.

My beloved has turned cruel and sits apart, dear friend; how much sorrow can Ramji endure?

5. Tirhut

Cruel Shyam has not returned, dear friend, though he gave his solemn word.

How shall I spend my days, dear friend? There is no other who cares for me.

My eyes rain tears, my body is drenched, dear friend; desire wears me down day after day.

The vermilion on my head gives no delight, dear friend, nor the ornaments at my ears.

How pitiless the Creator has become, dear friend; he knows nothing of another's pain.

Ramji's hope will not be fulfilled, dear friend; the god of love has pronounced his verdict.

6. Bhajan Bhairavi

Now, O mind, become devoted to Hari's feet.

Give up the many longings of your heart; abandon pride and deceit.

Children, wife, kin and townsfolk will be of no use in the end.

The feet on which gods, human beings and sages meditate—awake to them now, even in the night.

Worship merciful Raghupati, who has rescued thousands of the fallen.

Without worship of Hari, the days pass in vain; the world is like a dream.

Ramji, set aside every other reliance and cling now to Sita's lord.

7. Raga Vihag

Who else is there without Rama? The Lord who went and saved Ahalya, who had stood transformed into stone; who rescued the elephant Gajendra from the water on hearing its call; who lengthened Draupadi's garment in the assembly, as the whole world knows. Ramji, worship Sita's lord night and day, foolish one, if you desire happiness.

8. Thumri for Chait

Chait has come, yet my beloved has not, O Rama; my heart is troubled.

The house gives no pleasure, love torments me, and sleep will not come to my eyes.

Night and day the cuckoo keeps calling; every garden is filled with flowers.

For Ramji the spring season passes in vain if his beloved does not embrace him, O Rama.

My heart is troubled; in Chait my beloved has not come.

9. Thumri for Chait

The hostile month of Chait has arrived, O Rama; fate has turned against me.

I spread my red-and-red patterned veil upon the bed, but my beloved did not come even in a dream.

Youth's force grows day by day; my home tastes like poison.

Ramji says, life in this body is wasted; Lord, why have my eyes not seen you?

10. Thumri for Chait

The son of the Wind has come searching for Sita, O Rama.
Again and again they forbade him, yet none of the demons could prevail against him in battle.
He destroyed the grove in anger; the lord of Lanka speaks to Meghavada.
Do not kill him, son; bind him and bring him here, so that Ramji may understand the reason, O Rama.

11. Maheshvani

Listen, listen, Lord Chandeshvara; cast one merciful glance upon me, for I am utterly orphaned.
I served so many gods, demons and kings; none stood beside me in distress.
Deeply disappointed, I have placed my head at your feet with one last hope.
Wandering everywhere, I learned what pleased each person; everyone stood by self-interest.
Those counted as friends and needed relatives have all left me to suffer.
I know nothing of the Vedas or Puranas, nor the proper sentiments of worship.
Night and day I am burdened by the worry of filling my stomach and by idle talk.
The world knows that you are ever merciful toward the poor.
Fulfil all Ramji's aspirations, O Bhola Nath.

12. Maheshvani

Bam Bhola is beyond price; how many sorrowing people
Have I seen coming to him in utter distress!
Some bear suffering of body or destiny,
Others endure worldly affliction;
Some come seeking the hope of grain or money.
Some suffer for wife and children; others have many different troubles;
Some worship you for the sake of the highest good.
You sit in the thicket like a philosopher's stone, taking away everyone's suffering.
Ramji cannot say what he deserves, laden with offences as he is.

13. Maheshvani

What a remarkable bridegroom they have found for Parvati!
He has neither household nor wealth nor relatives, and will not be bound by caste or rank.
He beats his damaru on the mountain, playing night and day with ghosts and spirits.
He grows no grain at all; hemp and datura he has in plenty.

Venomous serpents hang as ornaments from every limb; the sight makes one shudder.

All the signs of perfect madness are upon him; he has smeared his limbs with ash.

Forsaking elephants, horses and the palanquin, he rides upon a great bull.

Ramji says: good fortune has now awakened!

The Lord of the three worlds will be Gauri's husband; prepare the wedding of Purahara.

14. Maheshvani

My life too has passed away in vain.

I never plucked a bilva leaf, nor did I cultivate flowers.

I never worshipped Shankara with rice, incense, lamps and sandalwood.

Nights and days slipped away as I entertained desire after desire.

Not once did I sit with a peaceful mind in meditation and chant 'Bam, Bam.'

Caught in thoughts of wife and children, my mind found no rest.

Worrying and worrying, my days passed; now this body has grown frail.

Ramji says: abandon every other hope and serve the wondrous Shiva.

Resolve in your heart that none but Shiva can remove unbearable sorrow.

15. Maheshvani

I have heard that Shiva is compassionate;

When will he listen to the suffering person's plea?

Hail him who bears the Ganga and the moon upon his brow, a garland of skulls at his throat, overcome with bhang.

Parvati occupies his left side; riding the bull, he carries a thousand serpents upon his limbs.

Lord of spirits, protector of those who bow, sky-clad one,

With ash upon his body, goblins beside him, a damaru and a tiger skin.

When will you take notice of poor Ramji?

Without Shiva, who will sustain me?

16. Maheshvani

Shiva, cut through this tangle of troubles.

How much longer shall I recount my plight?

Night and day there is no peace; hunger has become a torment.

In my anxiety I even forgot to think of you.

Friends and family held out many promises of good,

But none came to help when hardship grew severe.

Ramji's one hope is you; if you do not look upon him, he will remain distraught.

17. Maheshvani

Shiva, explain this to me:
To whom shall I go and tell my suffering?
I can find no one equal to you,
One who would hear and come at once to help.
Friends, companions, wife and children—even health—seem dear;
But seeing me penniless, they hide and turn away.
Bam Bhola Vaidyanath, receive the poor; seated in the thicket,
You scatter rubies and diamonds as gifts.
Ramji waits in hope; look upon him with merciful eyes,
O Lord, take him into your care.
Here ends the section.
May there be accomplishment; may there be well-being.

18. Prayerful Bhajan

Who but the Lord can save us from suffering?
How many afflicted people have you rescued in this world, carrying them across the ocean of existence as if it were without water? I have made so many mistakes, yet you do not seem to hear my cry. Your name has become ‘Redeemer of the Fallen’: uphold the pledge of that name, Lord, for I remain profoundly unworthy. If you show no compassion to this servant, who else will learn of his plight? Ramji has no other refuge for one so fallen.

19. Supplication to Lakshmi-Narayana

Lakshmi-Narayana, why do you not look toward me?
Everyone calls you merciful toward the poor.
Why do you shrink from the terrible sight of my sorrow?
You rescued the hunter, the courtesan, the vulture, Ajamila and the elephant.
You rescued the lowly Kaul, the Kirata and the Bhil woman.
Who could count how many fallen people you have delivered?
You have gone to Bhola Nath's abode in Rudrapur.
If you show me no mercy, what am I to do?
Keep Ramji, one orphaned servant, in your care.

20. Prayer to the Goddess

Victory, victory to Mother Janaka's daughter; you are the refuge of the three worlds.
You alone sustain the world, even Shesha, Ganesha and the gods.
No one can fully tell your glory; even the gods and their lord are humbled.

I am profoundly afflicted in this world: who in the three worlds does not know it?
I place my only hope at your feet; protect this unworthy servant.
No one else has been able to grant shelter; see how the poor are suffering.
If you will show no mercy, Mother of the World, know this in your heart:
Who then will remove my sorrow? I have abandoned all but you.
If ever you find an opportunity, tell the Lord of Ayodhya of my troubles.
Ramji has no support other than your feet.

21. Prayerful Bhajan

Who but the Lord can deliver us from sorrow?
How many suffering people have you saved in this world,
Carrying them across the ocean of existence as though it were without water!
How many mistakes I have committed;
My voice does not seem to reach your ears.
You are known by the name Redeemer of the Fallen.
Uphold that name, O Lord; I am a wretched one.
If you will not show mercy to this servant, who else will hear of him?
Ramji, fallen as he is, has no other refuge.

22. Vihag

Bhola, look upon me for a single instant.
You have rescued so many suffering people in this world; where have you gone now that my turn has come?
Lord of spirits, Shankara, beloved of Gauri, remove my distress this time.
If you do not show compassion, Shiva-Shankara, who else will ease this pain?
Knowing you to be most merciful, I have come to your shelter, having heard of your fame.
Ramji has no other refuge—no one else at all.

23. Maheshvani Bhajan

Bhola, when will you deliver me from sorrow?
The threefold afflictions come to torment me; they seek to take my life.
Night and day they remain with me; there is not a moment's rest.
I have exhausted every remedy, and my suffering grows stronger by the day.
If you do not show mercy, Shiva-Shankara, who else will remove my pain?
Keep Ramji in your shelter, Lord; know that he is the foremost among the unworthy. O Bhola!

24. Prayer in Vihag

Who but Rama can take away my sorrow?
The merciful lord of Kosala, gentle of heart,
Upon whom the sages fix their minds.
In this world you have rescued multitudes of the fallen,
Among them the courtesan, foremost of the lost.
You saved the boatman, the vulture and Ajamila,
Even though your name was spoken unknowingly.
There is no other as merciful as you,
No one so richly endowed.
Ramji cries out, having nowhere else to turn: save me from worldly existence, O Rama! [Refrain: Without Rama.]

25. Prayerful Bhajan

Lakshmi-Narayana, when will you remove my sorrow?
Redeemer of the Fallen—everyone gives you that name.
Why are you so stern when my turn comes?
The threefold suffering torments me constantly, night and day.
Who but you will deliver me?
I have served so many gods, demons and human beings,
Yet none helped me when calamity came.
How much shall I tell you, if you will not show mercy?
Who will shelter Ramji, apart from you?

26. Prayerful Bhajan

Look upon me once, O Lord.
Without you there is no one else to take away sorrow.
Night and day I never find a moment's peace;
No one else turns to look at me.
My sole hope rests at your feet: come and deliver me.
You have rescued so many fallen people that no one could count them,
Yet you do not seem to hear my words;
Have your ears become so deaf?
Your mighty power is renowned in this world;
Who does not know of it?
The courtesan, the vulture, Ajamila and the elephant—
You saved their lives, even from the water.
If you do not show mercy, descendant of Raghu,
Disaster is certain to overtake me.
Ramji has no refuge left now,

No one else at all.

27. Maheshvani

Listen, listen, O merciful one;
Who else is as compassionate as you?
Whoever comes to seek your shelter,
You have filled them all with joy.
When will you take away my suffering?
Tell me, O Jhāṛī Lal.
The Ganga adorns your matted locks; the moon rests upon your brow.
You dwell at Jhāṛī and show such care for those in sorrow.
Keep Ramji in your refuge;
Listen, listen, O Mahakala;
Take away my affliction, Shiva, and come to protect me.

28. Maheshvani

Cut through the entanglement of suffering;
Show mercy, generous Chandeshvara; cut through this snare of sorrows.
If you show no compassion, Shiva-Shankara,
To whom else shall I speak?
Each day I grow more distressed; how much pain must I bear
If you refuse to heed my plight?
The Ganga shines among your matted hair;
The moon rises upon your brow.
You carry a deer skin and play the damaru;
You drink bhang all three times of the day.
Take your trident and cut through my suffering;
Quickly bring me relief from sorrow.
Ramji sets his hopes on you alone;
Be mindful of him and remove his distress.

29. Maheshvani

Shiva, protect me;
Who else can be as compassionate as you?
Ash upon your limbs, the Ganga on your head, the moon like a mark upon your brow;
You drink bhang and abide in delight,
Yet do not forget the suffering.
You roam upon the bull,
Accompanied by hosts of spirits;
You play the damaru, and your three

Eyes are vast.
You dwell at Jhāṛī,
Scattering precious diamonds and rubies;
Yet when Ramji's turn came, Shiva had become impoverished!

30. Maheshvani

Shiva, why have you made me so poor? Why so poor?
Day and night I find no peace;
My anxieties remain divided and troubled,
And on top of them the threefold torments
Seek to exhaust me.
My wife and children pay no heed to what I say;
Other relatives too seem bent on taking my life.
Knowing you to be exceedingly merciful, I came weeping to your shelter;
Remove Ramji's sorrow, knowing him to be one without refuge.

31. Maheshvani

Fate has inflicted a terrible sorrow:
Why did it decree such a husband for dear Gauri?
He has neither caste nor lineage nor relatives,
And lives alone upon the mountain.
He beats his damaru, dances to himself, and plays with ghosts and spirits.
His body is smeared with ash; the Ganga adorns his head,
And the moon rises upon his brow.
There is not a single garment on his body;
Over it he wears a tiger skin.
Poisonous serpents hang from his limbs,
And a garland of skulls adorns his throat.
Why do you worry, Maina? Ramji asks;
Gauri will live happily and be blessed.

32. Vihag

Look upon Vrindavan in every direction.
See Kali-daha and Vamshivata,
The leafy bowers and lanes everywhere;
Behold the Lord in Seva Kunj,
And dance there once.
See the lovely bathing steps on the Yamuna's bank,
Where so many travellers have stayed;
See the bending kadamba trees,
And places where garments are hung.

Ramji says: Vrindavan is Vaikuntha;
Wander through all its places.
See the beauty of the rasa circle;
Stay a few more days.

33. Vihag

Go and see the sights of Mathura.
There are ghats built of stone,
And their sound carries far;
Along the banks of the holy Yamuna,
So many places are silent.
See the pillars made of eight metals,
And electric lights blazing everywhere;
See the splendour in the heart of the city,
And the many heaps of sand.
Drains run along both sides,
And stonework is abundant.
See the fortress of King Kamsa,
And remember Devaki and Vasudeva.
See the warriors Chanura and Mushtika,
And the house of Kubja too;
See the temple of Radha and Krishna,
And the temple of Dauji as well.
Leave aside the Vihag.
Ramji, go now and wander through Madhuban,
Where Krishna once dwelt.
See Gokul, Nanda and Yashoda,
And rock Krishna's cradle once.

34. Maheshvani

Bhola, why have you become so hard-hearted?
Turn your gaze toward me just once.
Ash covers your body, and the Ganga rests upon your head;
The moon on your brow shines brilliantly.
The bull is your mount, a rudra garland about your throat;
You play with ghosts and spirits.
Lord of the three worlds, Gauri's husband, if you will not look upon me even once,
Who then will remove my sorrow?
My life cannot endure much more.
Knowing you to be deeply merciful, I came

To your shelter, having heard your renown.
Ramji cries out, without refuge;
Grant me a vision of you, if only once.

35. Prayerful Bhajan

Listen, listen, O Lord;
Without you,
My unworthy life is slipping away.
I have entreated so many gods, night and day,
But none has heard my appeal.
Knowing you to be very merciful, I have come to your shelter.
My friends and relations are all very wealthy,
Yet at the sight of my sorrow, they think only of their own loss.
Ramji, despairing of all else, trusts in you alone;
Look upon me graciously, O Lord,
Knowing I am without refuge.

36. Maheshvani

Look, look, O Maina;
The bridegroom for dear Gauri has arrived;
How shall we receive him with the wedding rites?
His body is smeared with ash, the moon upon his brow,
Venomous snakes cover every limb;
How shall I go near him?
A tiger skin is his covering, a garland of skulls his ornament;
Ghosts and spirits accompany him—what kind of wedding party is this?
A trident and damaru in his hands, a tiger skin and strange eyes;
Forsaking elephants, horses and a palanquin, he rides upon a dwarf-like bull.
Ramji says: listen, O Maina;
This bridegroom too is exceedingly accomplished.
He is the master of all three worlds;
Accept him as your son-in-law.

37. Maheshvani

How can we give dear Gauri to such a husband?
Snakes cover his whole body, and a tiger skin serves him as a cloak;
His body is smeared with ash—how fearsome he looks!
The Ganga roars in his matted hair;
How strange the garland of skulls around his neck!
A crescent moon sits upon his head like a tilak;

Abandoning elephants, horses and the palanquin, he rides a diminutive bull.
Ramji says: listen, O Maina; dear Gauri is immensely fortunate
To have obtained the Lord of Kailash in this way.

38. Bhajan Vihag

Who but Rama will take away my distress?
The most gracious lord of Kosala
Knows the truth of everything;
No one as low, crooked, cowardly and wicked as I
Will be found anywhere else.
Come now into Hari's shelter and look at him for one moment;
He saved the courtesan, the vulture and Ajamila,
And countless other fallen souls.
I have fallen into an ocean of grief;
If you will not seek me out, Lord,
Who else will take away my suffering,
Apart from you?
Night and day I am trapped in calamity, and have no other helper;
Keep Ramji, who has no refuge, in your shelter;
Look upon me now with merciful eyes.

39. Bhajan Vihag

Cut away my troubles, O Lord.
Your servant is surrounded by enemies one after another;
Protect him, O brave descendant of Raghu.
Many enemies oppress me as well;
Come and deliver me.
You went into the waters and saved Gajendra,
Leaving even Garuda behind in the open field;
You lengthened Draupadi's garment in the assembly,
Piling it high as the sky.
You made friends of the boatman and the monkeys,
And gave the vulture a place in your own abode;
You took Vibhishana into your protection
And granted him a kingdom for an age.
You rescued many more unworthy people,
Among them Shabari and the hunter;
Ramji has come to your shelter,
His misery reaching its utmost limit.

40. Maheshvani

I shall always call him the Lord of Jhāṛīkhaṇḍ, Jhāṛīkhaṇḍ.
A trident in his hand, the Ganga upon his head,
Ash adorning his body;
I shall always call him the bearer of the damaru, the bearer of the damaru.
I shall call him the moon-crested one;
I shall always call him the bearer of serpents, the bearer of serpents.
I shall call him the most gracious sky-clad one; I shall call him Gauri-Shankara.
Remove Ramji's calamities;
I shall call him the protector of those without refuge.

41. Chait Naradi Janani

The month of Chait, king of seasons, has passed; my heart has grown restless.
Love has driven me almost mad; the arrows of flowers have struck me.
The jasmine vines, roses and mango trees have bloomed in abundance;
Bees hum in every direction—how shall I find peace?
Each night passes like an age; my house gives me no delight.
Hearing call upon call, how many tears will pour down?
Ramji will now surrender his life; how much longer can the waiting last?
The Lord went to Madhupur and never returned.

42. Bhajan to Lakshmi-Narayana

Lakshmi-Narayana, why do you not look toward me?
Everyone calls you merciful to the poor;
Yet even you shrink at the sight of my grievous sorrow.
You saved the hunter, the courtesan, the vulture, Ajamila and the elephant;
You rescued the Kaul, the Kirata, the Bhil woman and the lowly;
Who can count the many fallen people you have delivered?
You went to Bhola Nath's dwelling in Rudrapur.
If you will not show me mercy, what shall I do?
Keep Ramji, a solitary orphaned servant, in your care.

43. Maheshvani

Shiva, look upon me for a single instant.
I have fallen into an ocean of sorrow;
Row me across it this time.
If you show me no mercy, Shiva-Shankara,
I will not survive here.
The threefold afflictions have come to torment me

And wish to take my life.
Ramji has no other support; one without refuge, he has come into your shelter.

44. Samdaun

My day of departure to my husband's home has drawn near;
Come together, dear friends, and meet me, all of you.
When shall I come again into this world, a young bride,
From the distant land of my husband's house?
Day and night I remained forgetfully among my friends,
And did none of my own work.
Suddenly the heart has grown restless, as I realise
How shall I manage the work that lies before me?
Who will accompany me, and what message or provisions can I take?
The road to that distant land is long.
No loan or borrowed help will be found there;
The path is strewn with kusa grass and thorns.
All of you, show me kindness now;
Forgive whatever offences remain.
Ramji, what use will regret be now?
How shall I journey to that far-off land?

45. Maheshvani

How much arduous penance did you perform, Gauri,
To obtain such a husband?
Snakes hiss and hiss upon all his limbs;
A tiger skin lies across his body,
And a garland of skulls is his ornament.
There is a tiger beside him, and he rides a bull;
How strangely the ghosts and spirits dance around him!
The Ganga roars among his matted locks;
How the moon shines upon his brow!
Ramji says: listen, O Maina;
Gauri's marriage is auspicious indeed; give up your stubborn objection.

37. Vidyapati's Bidesiya: The Beloved in a Distant Land

Abstract

Bhojpuri literature is less extensive than Maithili literature, but that is only in quantity; in several respects it is ahead in quality. I say this with reference to Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya in Bhojpuri. Bhikhari Thakur had lived as a migrant in Calcutta. On returning, he travelled from village to village across the Bhojpur region, singing and giving moving accounts of the hardships he had endured. Out of this emerged the play Bidesiya.

Keywords: Vidyapati · Bidesiya · beloved abroad · literary criticism · Maithili

Bhojpuri literature is less abundant than Maithili literature, but only in quantity: in several respects it is ahead in quality. I say this in connection with Bhikhari Thakur's Bhojpuri Bidesiya. Thakur had lived as a migrant in Calcutta; after his return he travelled from village to village in the Bhojpur region, singing poignant accounts of his experiences. This became the play Bidesiya. Migration from Mithila is a phenomenon of the present age, when entire villages have emptied and migrants from Mithila have spread to every corner of the country. Earlier, however, Mithila did not experience migration in the same way as Bhojpur. Movement was largely confined to Morang, a region of Nepal's Mithila. As a result, Maithili folk ballads tend to lack fine-grained narrative detail. What detail exists often reads not as the experience of a folk hero but as a heavy, epic-style account of a hero. It has no equivalent to Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya. Consider the story of Salhes: across a regional boundary Salhes may change from king to thief and from thief to king. Likewise, in the case of Chuharmal, where Salhes is regarded as king, Chuharmal may be the thief; where Salhes is called a thief, Chuharmal may be the king or the powerful figure. Yet none of this has been researched. While looking through Vidyapati's Padavali, I encountered songs of many kinds. Most describe the separation of lovers, rather than the central predicament of Bidesiya: being compelled to migrate for employment and a livelihood. Eventually I found some genuine Bidesiya songs, which Vidyapati calls Piya Desantar—the beloved in a distant land. Unsurprisingly, most came from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali, and one from the collection edited by Nagendranath Gupta. A possible reason is that Morang, part of Mithila in Nepal, was known as a destination for migration.

On this basis I present the following short dramatic composition.

Vidyapati's Piya Desantar (The Beloved in a Distant Land)

Scene 1

Onstage, our migrant leaves home to take a job in a distant land, while the young woman sings. A traveller arrives in the middle of the song. At the other end of the stage, thieves crouch in hiding. On the opposite side, the constable and a white-dhoti-clad man sit unconcernedly, their hands resting on their bellies.

Dhanachhi Raga (from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali)

> I am a young woman; my husband has gone abroad. No neighbours live anywhere near me.
>
> I am a young woman and my husband has gone to a distant land. Not even a trace of a neighbour remains nearby.
>
> My mother-in-law and sister-in-law understand nothing; they suffer night blindness and cannot hear.
>
> My mother-in-law and sister-in-law understand nothing either; they have difficulty seeing in the dark and cannot hear properly.
>
> Awake, traveller; do not set off before dawn. The night is dark and the village is full of thieves.
>
> Traveller, give up sleep. Do not come before daybreak: the night is dark and there are many thieves in the village.
>
> The constable does not keep watch, even in dreams; even when appealed to, he gives it no thought.
>
> The constable never stands guard, not even in his dreams; even when invited to intervene, he does not consider the matter.
>
> The king does not punish anyone here;
>
> All the important men belong to our own kind.
>
> That is why the king punishes no one, while all the powerful people are alike.
>
> The poet Vidyapati sings this sentiment, making its feeling known through poetic expression.
>
> The poet Vidyapati sings of this experience and conveys its meaning through figurative words.

The poet Vidyapati enters. A white-dhoti-clad man and a poor man approach the constable. On the strength of appearances alone, the constable decides in favour of the man in white. The young woman, sitting in another corner of the stage, beats her head in distress. Vidyapati sings the last four lines of the song.

Scene 2

The young woman opens a shop, indicated symbolically. From the opposite side of the stage, the mother-in-law and sister-in-law depart, while a traveller arrives as a customer. The young woman begins to sing. After every line Vidyapati comes onto the stage, gives its meaning, and vanishes into darkness. But Vidyapati sings the last line himself, and the young woman explains its meaning.

Malava Raga (from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali)

How cool the shade of this tree; villages lie scattered from place to place.

The shade of this tree is very cool; villages are settled here and there.

I am alone; my beloved is in a distant land; no wicked man is spoken of here.

I am alone and my beloved is abroad; nowhere does one hear the name of an evil man.

O traveller, rest here a while.

Traveller, please take your rest here.

Whatever you wish to buy will not be dear; everything is available in this place.

Whatever you buy will be inexpensive; you can find everything here.

My mother-in-law is not at home; my relations are elsewhere, and my sister-in-law is simple by nature.

My mother-in-law is away, the family are far off, and my sister-in-law is straightforward by nature.

If you still turn away and leave, traveller, I can do nothing more.

Even after all this, if you go away unwilling to stay, the matter is no longer in my hands.

Vidyapati says: listen, young woman, you who live in hope of another's town.

Vidyapati says: young woman, listen—you are fulfilling another person's hope.

Scene 3

Vidyapati is absent from this scene. The young woman's sister-in-law is scolding the traveller; the sight reminds the woman of her beloved abroad. Addressing her sister-in-law and her companion, she sings. After each line, the companion gives its meaning.

Dhanachhi Raga (from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali)

In a foreign land one depends upon others; do not turn the traveller away —give him a place to stay.

In a distant land one must continually depend on other people. So no one should be turned away; one should certainly offer shelter.

Understand this much, dear friend, of the beloved's plight.

Friend, understand at least this much about one's beloved.

Sister-in-law, weigh good and ill in your mind; do not address the traveller harshly.

Sister-in-law, think about what is right and wrong; do not speak broken, harsh words to the traveller.

Wash his feet, give him a seat, and comfort him with gentle words.

Wash his feet, offer a place to sit, and speak kindly to reassure him.

Friend, it would be wrong to let him go so far away; show him still greater respect.

Friend, it would be unjust for the traveller to leave this place; honour him even more.

Scene 4

The young woman and her sister-in-law have come to the town and found lodging. When a traveller arrives asking for shelter, the woman sings and the sister-in-law explains the meaning after each line. In the middle, four lines are sung from offstage without explanation. The young woman then continues to sing, and the sister-in-law provides the explanations. Finally Vidyapati enters and sings the last two lines. At the end of the scene the sister-in-law asks: 'You disliked my scolding the traveller that day, so why did you refuse shelter to a traveller today?'

Kolara Raga (from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali)

I am alone; my beloved is not in the village; that is why I hesitate to offer a place for the night.

I am alone, and my beloved is not in the village. That is why I feel uncertain about telling someone to spend the night here.

Elsewhere I would have offered shelter, if only there had been another neighbour nearby.

If someone had been living near us, I would have shown the traveller another place to stay.

Forgive me, traveller; what can I do? Go through the town and look elsewhere for lodging.

Forgive me, traveller, and go; seek shelter somewhere else in the town.

Open country lies between us, and evening has come; in a foreign place act with care for what is to come.

There is open countryside in between, evening has fallen, and one must act with an eye to the future when away from home.

My heart is scattered moment by moment; how can youth remain concealed when desire awakens?

Go, go, traveller—what am I to do? Wander through the town and seek lodging elsewhere.

Seven or five houses had been readied for him; my beloved went abroad, and a distance opened between us.

He set a limit of twelve years; four years have already passed since he left.

Terrible rain clouds split the night; consider carefully what you must do.

The clouds are threatening; this is a matter of the night, so decide after taking thought.

Vidyapati says: this is the way of town-dwellers—love is stirred through indirect, cutting speech.

Vidyapati says that such is the custom of the town: affection is brought forth by bitter words.

Scene 5

Vidyapati is not present in this scene either. A traveller arrives, but seeing neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law in the house, he declines to stay out of embarrassment and moves on. The young woman sings.

Ghanachhi Raga (from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali)

My situation suits the thief called Manmatha; an elderly maidservant stands guard.

My circumstances are just right for the thief who is the god of love; the old maid is keeping watch.

He gave a term of twelve years; four years have passed since he went.

The promised period was twelve years; he departed then, and four years have passed since.

Even the traveller who seeks shelter is ashamed; neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law is here.

Neither my mother-in-law nor sister-in-law is present, and even the traveller feels embarrassed at the thought of being given shelter.

Five or seven houses he prepared; then my beloved went to a distant land and came to be separated from me.

He prepared a house for the god of desire and left for a distant country; a distance arose between us.

The neighbour's dwelling has become as distant as a hundred yojanas; everyone has gone away to different places.

A neighbour's house now seems a hundred yojanas away; all my relatives have gone here and there.

The evening dark hides everything; the neighbour has fastened the gate.

The gathering of people has vanished into darkness, and the woman next door has shut her gate.

My mind wanders again and again; how long can I conceal my going when Manmatha is awake?

My heart flees from one thought to another; the god of love is awake—how much longer can I hide my movements?

Scene 6

Here too there is neither sister-in-law, nor mother-in-law, nor Vidyapati. A guest arrives, and at that very moment the clouds burst into rain. The young woman sings.

Dhanachhi Raga (from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali)

I was seated in my own house; there was no one else at home.

I was sitting at home; nobody else was in the house.

Just then a traveller arrived as my guest, and the heavens began to rain.

At that moment the traveller arrived, and it started to rain heavily.

Who knows what the spiteful neighbour will say, now that she has found a chance to speak?

I do not know what the jealous woman next door will say; she has been handed an opportunity to talk.

Pitch darkness and unceasing rain have made day appear like night.

Even in daylight it has begun to look like night.

What can I say, and who will believe me? The world knows the power of the five-arrowed god of love.

To whom can I speak, and who will trust me? The fame of Kamadeva is known throughout the world.

Scene 7

From one side of the stage, the mother-in-law's body is carried out following her death, and the stage falls dark. When the lights return, the sister-in-law's husband takes her to her marital home. The traveller stands in the aisle among the audience. Gesturing toward the spectators, the young woman sings, and after each line Vidyapati explains its meaning. For the final two lines Vidyapati speaks both the song and its interpretation. He repeats those final two lines and their meanings several times.

From the Padavali edited by Nagendranath Gupta

My mother-in-law grew old and passed away; my sister-in-law too went to her husband's home.

My mother-in-law has died; my sister-in-law too has gone to her marital home.

There is no one left to see; no one with whom to stay awake at night and talk.

There is no one even to converse with.

Such is the conduct of this town: nobody asks after anybody else.

The way people behave here is such that no one inquires after another.

Tell my beloved: how many more days must I, a woman alone, remain like this?

Tell my beloved: how long am I to stay by myself?

Traveller, tell my husband not to abandon the joy of love with a woman like me.

Traveller, tell him: how long will the passionate glow of a woman such as I endure?

Vidyapati says, singing: the woman separated from her beloved wanders about, entreating the traveller.

Vidyapati sings: the woman in separation goes about telling her story to the traveller.

As Vidyapati sings, he falters a little. Darkness begins to spread. One figure can dimly be seen emerging from the darkness toward the young woman. Is it he, the beloved returned from the distant land? Yes—or perhaps not!

The strains of Piya Desantar are heard; as music sounds, the curtain falls.

This conception of Piya Desantar is placed before discerning readers and respectfully dedicated to the great poet Vidyapati, amid the present suffering of Maithili migrants scattered far from home.

Supplementary Discussion

Bhojpuri literature is less abundant than Maithili literature, but only in quantity: in several respects it is ahead in quality. I say this in connection with Bhikhari Thakur's Bhojpuri Bidesiya. Thakur had lived as a migrant in Calcutta; after his return he travelled from village to village in the Bhojpur region, singing poignant accounts of his experiences. This became the play Bidesiya. Migration from Mithila is a phenomenon of the present age, when entire villages have emptied and migrants from Mithila have spread to every corner of the country. Earlier, however, Mithila did not experience migration in the same way as Bhojpur. Movement was largely confined to Morang, a region of Nepal's Mithila. As a result, Maithili folk ballads tend to lack fine-grained narrative detail. What detail exists often reads not as the experience of a folk hero but as a heavy, epic-style account of a hero. It has no equivalent to Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya. Consider the story of Salhes: across a regional boundary Salhes may change from king to thief and from thief to king. Likewise, in the case of Chuharmal, where Salhes is regarded as king, Chuharmal may be the thief; where Salhes is called a thief, Chuharmal may be the king or the powerful figure. Yet none of this has been researched. While looking through Vidyapati's Padavali, I encountered songs of many kinds. Most describe the separation of lovers, rather than the central predicament of Bidesiya: being compelled to

migrate for employment and a livelihood. Eventually I found some genuine Bidesiya songs, which Vidyapati calls Piya Desantar—the beloved in a distant land. Unsurprisingly, most came from Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali, and one from the collection edited by Nagendranath Gupta. A possible reason is that Morang, part of Mithila in Nepal, was known as a destination for migration.

Onstage, our migrant leaves home to take a job in a distant land, while the young woman sings. A traveller arrives in the middle of the song. At the other end of the stage, thieves crouch in hiding. On the opposite side, the constable and a white-dhoti-clad man sit unconcernedly, their hands resting on their bellies.

I am a young woman; my husband has gone abroad. No neighbours live anywhere near me.

I am a young woman and my husband has gone to a distant land. Not even a trace of a neighbour remains nearby.

Awake, traveller; do not set off before dawn. The night is dark and the village is full of thieves.

How cool the shade of this tree; villages lie scattered from place to place.

Vidyapati is absent from this scene. The young woman's sister-in-law is scolding the traveller; the sight reminds the woman of her beloved abroad. Addressing her sister-in-law and her companion, she sings. After each line, the companion gives its meaning.

Friend, it would be wrong to let him go so far away; show him still greater respect.

Friend, it would be unjust for the traveller to leave this place; honour him even more.

Elsewhere I would have offered shelter, if only there had been another neighbour nearby.

Vidyapati is not present in this scene either. A traveller arrives, but seeing neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law in the house, he declines to stay out of embarrassment and moves on. The young woman sings.

My situation suits the thief called Manmatha; an elderly maidservant stands guard.

My circumstances are just right for the thief who is the god of love; the old maid is keeping watch.

The neighbour's dwelling has become as distant as a hundred yojanas; everyone has gone away to different places.

A neighbour's house now seems a hundred yojanas away; all my relatives have gone here and there.

The evening dark hides everything; the neighbour has fastened the gate.

The gathering of people has vanished into darkness, and the woman next door has shut her gate.

Who knows what the spiteful neighbour will say, now that she has found a chance to speak?

I do not know what the jealous woman next door will say; she has been handed an opportunity to talk.

The Forgotten Poet: Pandit Ramji Chaudhary

(1878–1952)

Ramji Chaudhary (1878–1952) was born in Rudrapur village, Andhratharhi police-station area, Madhubani district. His ancestral origin was Pagulbar Raje, of the Shandilya gotra. In the genealogy, Jivan Chaudhary, born in Panchobh in Darbhanga, came to Rudrapur in 1801. His two sons were Shri Rangi Chaudhary and Shri Kant Chaudhary, both born in Rudrapur. Kant Chaudhary had three sons: Shri Chumman Chaudhary, Shri Budhan Chaudhary and Shri Babua Chaudhary. Chumman Chaudhary had two sons: Shri Goni Chaudhary and the poet Pandit Ramji Chaudhary.

Shri Jivan Chaudhary was the poet's great-grandfather. His maternal relatives lived in Rudrapur, and it was for this reason that in 1801 he left Panchobh and settled there.

The poet's grandfather was an accomplished singer. His chief repertoire consisted of devotional songs addressed to the divine couple Sita and Rama, and this deeply influenced the poet. It was for this reason that he named his grandson Ramji. True to his name, the late poet had memorised Tulsidas's Shri Ramcharitmanas. He answered every question with a chaupai from the Ramayana. The most sorrowful circumstance of his life was that he married three times, yet none of his wives lived longer than four years after marriage. He married for the last time at the age of fifty-three. That wife died within fifteen days of giving birth to a son, Durganath Chaudhary (Dukhiya Chaudhary).

During his lifetime the poet served as a senior raiyat under the Darbhanga Raj. After the death of his third wife he resigned even from that position and devoted himself to worship. His sole published book and his unpublished manuscript contain poetry in Brajabuli as well as Maithili.

These poems bear the imprint of the poet's grandfather's knowledge of ragas; they also include Mithila's Maheshvani songs, Chait-month thumris and morning devotional songs, known as prabhati or parati.

Just as Shankardev composed in Maithili rather than Assamese, Ramji Chaudhary composed in Brajabuli as well as Maithili. Each of his poems identifies a raga, as do the Vidyapati lyrics recovered from Nepal. This influence seems to have come from his grandfather, himself a singer. The people of Mithila worship five deities, yet a Shiva shrine will be found in every village; accordingly, Ramji Chaudhary composed Maheshvani songs, thumris for the month of Chait, and morning hymns (parati or prabhati). The ragas and song forms named in his works are:

1. Raga Rekhta; 2. Lavani; 3. Raga Jhaptala; 4. Raga Dhrupad; 5. Raga Sangeet; 6. Raga Desh; 7. Raga Gauri; 8. Tirhut; 9. Bhajan Vinay; 10. Bhajan Bhairavi; 11. Bhajan Ghazal; 12. Holi; 13. Raga Shyam Kalyan; 14. Kavita; 15. Damphak Holi; 16. Raga Kagu Kafi; 17. Raga Vihag; 18. Ghazal Thumri; 19. Raga Pavas Chaumasa; 20. Bhajan Prabhati; 21. Maheshvani; and 22. Bhajan Kirtan.

The poet's compositions are presented here from his sole published book and from a manuscript he had Shri Harekant Chaudhary (now deceased) write out, obtained through Shri Shrimohan Chaudhary; these are available in the Videha archive at www.videha.co.in.

38. Vidyapati: A Refutation of Certain Widespread Misrepresentations

Abstract

Vidyapati's Sanskrit works bear the attribution "composed by Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati," and that Vidyapati was a Brahmin. My concern, however, is with the Vidyapati of Maithili. I have discussed why he was made to wear the pāg, so that he could be appropriated as "our Vidyapati." This did not happen during the eight hundred years in which non-Brahmin communities kept his work alive through Bidāpat Nāch. It occurred after Bengal laid claim to Vidyapati and Govindadas; after the Bengali scholar Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay was the first to assert that Vidyapati was a poet of the language of Mithila, and Nagendranath Gupta of Bengal was the first to say the same of Govindadas. At first all Bengal furiously opposed these claims, but eventually accepted them.

Keywords: Vidyapati · prevailing misrepresentations · refutation · literary criticism · Maithili

I

Vidyapati and the *pāg* in the parallel tradition

The Sanskrit works attributed to Vidyapati say "composed by Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati"; that Vidyapati was a Brahmin. My concern is the Vidyapati of Maithili. I have already discussed why a *pāg* was placed on his head and why he was converted into "our Vidyapati." This did not happen during the eight centuries when non-Brahmin communities sustained his living presence through *Bidāpat Nāch*. It happened after Bengal claimed Vidyapati and Govindadas, after Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay first identified Vidyapati as a poet of Mithila's language, and Nagendranath Gupta first identified Govindadas likewise. Bengal initially reacted with hostility, but later accepted these findings. Then the scholars of Mithila themselves became uneasy. By invoking Vidyapati's Sanskrit writings, and citing entries in the genealogical registers under the names Govindadas and Vidyapati, they produced "Vidyapati Thakur" and "Govindadas Jha" (!!!). Ramanath Jha's superficial understanding of the *Pañjī* and his restricted outlook did damage. Then, as if without warning, the Brahmin community placed the *pāg* on Vidyapati's head—the Vidyapati of Maithili, not the Sanskrit writer—and made him "our Vidyapati." Some people even began calling him a nephew of Jyotirishwar!

Yet the genealogical registers contain many poets like Kavīśvara Jyotirishwar. Why, then, does this variation in personal names arise in the case of Vidyapati but not in that of Jyotirishwar? Although the entire operation was planned, a piece of evidence still escaped their notice.

2. Why go all the way to Bengal? I have attended the worship of village deities in Purnia and seen Ram Thakur (a deity) represented as a god in the field where earthen clods were being raised; someone had lit a flame there.

3. They had migrated from Mithila to Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh. Prabhat Jha, a Rajya Sabha member from Madhya Pradesh, was saying that when the *barhī* community (carpenters) migrated from Mithila, people began addressing them as "Jhaji" because they spoke Maithili. They now use Jha as their surname. Prabhat Jha campaigned for one such candidate, who won by a single vote. We all know from experience that, whatever someone's original surname, even as far as Patna they may be called "Jhaji" or "Jhaua." In four or five villages of Malda district in Bengal, the surname of Maithil Brahmins is Ojha; in Aligarh, that of the Maithil Brahmins settled in Braj is Sharma.

4. The Pañjī genealogical registers contain the following entries for persons named Vidyapati (archival spellings and unexplained abbreviations preserved):
1. panicobha from vidyāpatisuta ramāpatika vivāha vidyāpatika- mātā (devadāsī)-dūṣaṇa paṃjī
2. maho keśavo suta ma. ma. pāō govinda sutā maho lakṣmīnātha ma. ma. vidyāpati ma. ma. dāmodara
3. mahāmaho vidyāpati gaṃgolī from mānakuḍha vāsī kavirāja gaṇeśvara
4. ghosotafrom ma. ma. govinda sutā ma. lakṣmīdhara ma. ma. vidyāpati
5. rājapaṇḍita ma. ma. u. vidyāpati
6. karamahāfrom devanātha suta kavi vidyāpati
7. guṇapati santati-paṭhoṅagī) . . vidyāpati-puḍarīka-machadī. keśava-amarāvatī.
8. . . siṃhāśrama fromvidyāpati ddauo bhāgīratha sutau kuleśvara:
9. sidhūka: e sutā delhana viśvanātha śrīnāthā: siṃhāśrama from vidyāpati dau. .
10. miśra jayadeva (76/06) sutā nagavāḍa ghosota from mahāmahopādhyāya vidyāpati dau
11. mahāmahopādhyāya govinda sutā mahāmaho lakṣmīnāthā paranāmaka (209/05) ṭhakarū mao mao upāo vidyāpati
12. ddauo. . evam ṭhao vidyāpati mātṛka cakraṃ. .
13. mahomahopādhyāya vidyāpati sutā anirūddha ananta acyutā: ekaharā from kāśī dau
14. saduosupe sutau dāmodara: e sutau ḍālūka: pavaulīfrom goḍhi dau ḍālū (34/06) suto vidyāpati
15. sutā śirū padama lākhū gādūkā: ekaharā from śrī kara suta cānda dau khauāla from bhūle ddauo madhusūdana sutā umāpati (84/01) vidyāpati
16. musai sutā khauāla from ḍālū suta vidyāpati dau bhaṇḍārisama from śubhe ddauo ṭhao
17. sodarapura from choṭāī dau (28/08) basāuna sutā paśupati vidyāpati

18. kalyāṇa sutā karamahā from vidyāpati dau
19. jālaya from rāmeś varasuta mahighara dau yamugāma from geṇāī ddauo vidyāpati suto bhagīratha:
20. harakhū govindā sakao guṇe suta vidyāpati dau suragana from hore ddauo
21. kṛṣṇapati sutā murāri vidyāpati prajāpati ṭakabāla from rāmakara dau. .
22. kavindra padāṃkita mao mao uo raghunāthā karamahā from vidyāpati dau
23. suto vidyāpati māṇḍarafrom yagyapati dau
24. talhanapura from gaḍhavaya ddau. vidyāpati
25. yaśu suto ravipati rūdrapati vidyāpati candrapati
26. narauna from vidyāpati dau
27. ravipati suto kṛṣṇapati vidyāpati ghusauta from hore dau. .
28. vidyāpati sutā belauṁca fromrāma dau
29. guṇe suta gaurīpati vidyāpati lakṣmīpati kulapatiya: dario divākara dau
30. mahipati jhāka mātāmaha kavi kokila vidyāpati ṭhākara) dāmodara suto pāṁsadu. harideva: naraunafrom māṅani dau
31. gaṇapati suto kavi kokila rājapaṇḍita mao mao upāo vidyāpati: e sutau haripati dhanapati. .
32. mahāmahopādhyāya vidyāpatisutā hṛṣikeśa
33. harapati sutā vidyāpati kāśī dāmodarā:
34. ratipati sutā sodarao vidyāpati dau
35. vidyāpati prapautra pautra hariśvara dhaneśvara suto gondūka pālīfrom jñānadau. .
36. vidyāpati ddau. veṇī suto ravinātha:
37. sodarao vidyāpati ddauo nikāra
38. śrīpati suto vidyāpati parānau dariharā
39. sodarao vidyāpati ddauo miśra kamalanayana sutā hariama from bachāī dau
40. ravauālafrom sone dau devanātha suto kavi vidyāpati pacahī sodarapurafrom jagannātha dau
41. gopī suto vidyāpati vācaspati śīvā hariamafrom nārāyaṇa dau. .
42. vidyāpati nidhi pra. dharāpatiya:
43. taraunī karamahāfrom mahidhara dau. . (46/03) vidyāpati (111/03) suto madhusūdana:
44. kulānanda hṛdayanan dano kara. panāī dau (109//106) vidyāpati (314/05) sutā pritinātha śobhanātha mahināthā:
45. uṁmāpati suta vidyāpati suto jayapati:
46. jāgū sutā surapati haripati prabhāpati girapati vidyāpatiya:
47. hacalū sutā harapati vidyāpati maho jñānapati dinapati maṇikaṃṭhā
48. kṛṣṇa sutā ramāpati śrīpati ratnapati vidyāpati: būdhavāla from dhīrū dau. .
49. dāśe sutā dayorī khaṇḍabalā from gopīnātha dau (85//02) vidyāpati suta jīvanātha

50. narauna from vidyāpati ddauo
51. dharmādhika raṇika bāṭū suto vidyāpati
52. sodarapura from gayana dau vidyāpati sutā ramāpati horila hararavū jivāīkā māṇḍara from soḍhū dau. .
53. khauāla from raghunātha dau (54//07) vidyāpati suta jānū
54. ṭakabālafrom vidyāpati ddau matinātha
55. khaṇḍabalāfrom vidyāpati suta jīvanātha dau
56. karamahā from vidyāpati ddauo viśvanātha
57. kṛṣṇapati suto uṁmāpati (bao 28/01) vidyāpati (302/03) paṇḍuā from pāṁ bhagīratha dau
58. maho harikṛṣṇa sutā khauāla from vidyāpati dau
59. madhusūdana suto vidyāpati: alaya from anirūddha dau
60. māṇḍara from devaśarmma ddauo vidyāpati sutā narauna from badanī dau
61. ṭhao śyāma suto purandara paramānando māṇḍara from vidyāpati dau
62. vidyāpati sutā sodarapura from jayarāma
63. dharmeśvarau khauāla from harāī suta manohara dau rūda suto rāma: gaṃgolī from deve dau visphī from kavi kokila rāja paṇḍita mao mao pāo vidyāpati ddauo rāma suto bhiravūka: phanandaha from locana dau pakaliyā from dinū ddauo bhiravū suto harāika: sodarapura from vira suta haridau khauāla from śubhe ddauo harāī sutā mohana manoharā kamala nārāyaṇā: sodarapura from jagannātha suta bhavānī dau bhavānī suto harideva sadāyakau hariama from govinda suta śrīdhara dau sakao jāge ddauo manohara sutā karamahā from ratanapati suta kṛṣṇadāśa dau kṛṣṇadāśa sutā sodarapura from madhusūdana suta sundara dau (47//05) dariharā from muśāī ddauo hari suto prāṇapati: sodarapura from nārāyaṇa suta nanū dau (110//01) (101//01) nārāyaṇa suto nanūka: vudhavāla from bahuḍa dau (180/04) dāmodara suto bahuḍa ka: sodarapura from paramānanda suta kāṃgava dau paramānanda suto kāṃgava: māṇḍara from halaghara suta pītāmbara dau (58//05) karamahā from śrīrāma ddauo kāṃgava sutā karamahā from śivadeva suta kārama dau māṇḍara from vāvū dauhitra dauo
64. vāvū durgāpati siṃha: suto vāvū vidyāpati siṃha: karamahā from harinātha suta tārānātha dau
65. khauāla from yuvarāja ddauo bāvū vidyāpati siṃha suto vāvū girijāpati siṃha
66. vāvū gaṃgāpati siṃha sutā bheṣapati siṃha vidyāpati siṃha
67. vāvū bheṣapati siṃha patnī antarjātīya e suta haṃsapati siṃha: vāvū vidyāpati siṃha suto ramana kumāra siṃha:
68. bālā suto bhaiyā kalyāṇau khauāla from vidyāpati dau
69. viśvanātha kāśīnāthā: alaya from vidyāpati dau
70. pāṭhaka vidyāpati suto dukhamaṃjana kalarau āsī ekaharā from uṁmānanda dau
71. narapati sutā kalyāṇapura visphī from sundara dau kamalanayana suta

nārāyaṇa suto sundara: karamahā from vidyāpati dau
72. murāri sutā dāmodara vidyāpati mahighara ānandā:
73. vidyāpati sutā padmāpati sabhāpati ādipati gaṇapatiya: . .
74. vidyāpati suto chītū paramānando māṇḍara from narapati dau baherāḍha from gadādhara ddauo
75. alaya from kamala suta nakaṭū dau. vidyāpati suta jīvanātha suto parama: dari. rāma dau. .
76. karamahā from vidyāpati suta madhusūdana dau
77. mānī sodarapura from vācaspati suta vidyāpati dau
78. khaṇḍabalā from vāvū durgāpati siṃha suta vāvū vidyāpati siṃha dau
79. khauāla from vidyāpati dau ṭha. madhurāpati suto vācha śivānandano
80. sodarapura from baidyanātha ddau. harikṛṣṇa sutā khauāla from madhusūdanasuta vidyāpati dau
81. madhusūdana suta vidyāpati dau
82. dariharā from ramāpati suta veṇī dau alaya from kṛṣṇapati suta vidyāpati ddau
83. alaya from vidyāpati ddau. ॥
84. jyo. śivanandana suto vidyāpati.
85. khauāla from bhavadeva suta vidyāpati dau.
86. pāṭhaka kṛṣṇapati suto uṣāpati vidyāpati.
87. vidyāpati suto dukhabhaṃjana kalaro ekaharā from devānanda suta uṁmānanda dau
88. alaya from vidyāpati suta kalaru dau
89. kāru sutā pitāmbara vidyāpati devakīmānā kā sodarapura from vaidayanātha suta jayi dau
90. suroi pra. śāradānanda sutā gaurīnandana vācaspati pra. vidyāpati divākara pra. mandū ratnākara pra. bhra. bholana jī kā naga. ghusauta from dāmodara suta ugramohana dau ekaharā from śobhānanda ddau.
91. khauāla from vidyāpati dau.

Let us return to the central issue. I have no doubt that the royal scholars and numerous holders of religious-judicial office called Vidyapati—including one who was the son of a *devadāsī*—were Brahmins. But I am not discussing Vidyapati Ṭhakkura or his *Kīrtilatā* and *Kīrtipatākā*; I am discussing the songs of the Vidyapati *Padāvalī*. Let there be no confusion on that point. Let us turn to the *Bidāpat* sung by non-Brahmins. This Vidyapati, I argue, lived before Jyotirishwar, possibly in the barber caste: Jyotirishwar's *Varṇa-Ratnākara* mentions this poet and his compositions.

Mahadeva was originally a god of non-Brahmin communities and was gradually adopted by Brahmins. Nowhere in the poems of Vidyapati's *Padāvalī* does their author claim to have written in Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭha. These songs express a pain on behalf of the dispossessed that is absent from

the writings in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha by the other, Brahmin Vidyapati. Why is that so? Consider an example.

Vidyapati's *Bidesiya*: *Piyā Desāntar* (The Beloved in a Distant Land)

Bhojpuri literature is less extensive than Maithili literature, but that is a matter of quantity alone; in several areas it is ahead in quality. I say this particularly with reference to Bhikhari Thakur's *Bidesiya*. Bhikhari Thakur lived as a migrant in Calcutta. After returning to the Bhojpur region, he went from village to village, singing of his suffering with such poignancy that his account became the play *Bidesiya*. Migration from Mithila is a phenomenon of our own times: entire villages have fallen silent, and migrants from Mithila are scattered throughout the country. Earlier, however, migration was not as widespread in Mithila as in the Bhojpur region. It was largely confined to Morang, the Mithila-speaking region of Nepal. Hence there is a striking lack of finely observed detail in Maithili folk narrative: even when such narratives exist, their heroes are described more like the heroes of epics than those of ordinary life. They are ponderous and cannot be compared with Bhikhari Thakur's *Bidesiya*. Consider the story of Salhes: when its regional boundaries change, Salhes becomes a thief instead of a king, and a king instead of a thief. Likewise, Chuharmal becomes a thief where Salhes is a king, and a king or powerful man where Salhes is called a thief. No serious research has been undertaken into these transformations. As I searched the verses of Vidyapati's *Padāvalī*, I came across various kinds of song. Most describe the pain of separation between lovers, rather than the central experience of the *bidesiya*: reluctant migration to earn one's livelihood. Eventually I found a few genuine songs of migrant separation, which Vidyapati calls *piyā desāntar*. Most, naturally, came from the Nepalese collection of his *Padāvalī*, and one from the collection edited by Nagendranath Gupta. Morang lies in Nepalese Mithila and was traditionally associated with labour migration; that may explain their provenance. On this basis I present the following short dramatic conception. *Vidyapati's Piyā Desāntar. *Scene 1. Onstage our migrant prepares to leave for employment abroad, while the young woman sings. A traveller enters during the song. Thieves crouch concealed at the opposite edge of the stage. Elsewhere the constable sits unconcerned beside a white-dhoti-clad man, resting a hand on his belly.* Rāga Dhanachhī* (Vidyapati's songs from Nepal): "I am young; my husband has gone to a distant land. Not even a neighbour's trace remains nearby." The singer explains: I am a young woman; my husband has gone away, and no neighbour remains close to me.

"Neither my mother-in-law nor my husband's sister knows anything; their eyes are night-blind, and their ears cannot hear." The mother-in-law and sister-in-law understand nothing: they suffer from night-blindness and are unable even to hear.

"Awaken, traveller; do not come at daybreak. The night is dark and the village full of thieves." Traveller, shake off your sleep. Do not come tomorrow morning; darkness covers the night and many thieves live in the village.

"Not even in dreams does the constable keep watch; even when approached, he gives no thought to the plea." The constable does not patrol even in a dream, and he pays no attention to an appeal for help.

"The ruler chastises no one here; the men of importance all belong to my own kind." Hence the king punishes nobody: all the powerful people are of one sort.

"Poet Vidyapati sings of this feeling, conveying his emotion through indirection." Vidyapati sings the experience and makes its meaning known through his manner of expression.

Poet Vidyapati enters. A man in a spotless white dhoti and a poor man approach the constable. By mere appearance the constable decides in favour of the white-dhoti-clad man; the young woman seated at the other corner of the stage beats her forehead in distress. Vidyapati sings the final four lines of the song. **Scene 2. The young woman symbolically opens a shop. As the mother-in-law and sister-in-law depart on the far side of the stage and a traveller arrives as a customer, she begins to sing. After each line Vidyapati appears, explains its meaning, and disappears into the darkness. At the final line, however, Vidyapati sings and the woman explains it.* Rāga Mālava* (Vidyapati's songs from Nepal): "How cool is this tree's shade! Villages appear at every stopping place." The shade of the tree is exceedingly cool, and villages are settled here and there. "I am alone, my beloved is abroad; here no evil person's name is heard." I am solitary; my beloved is in a distant land, and no one here speaks of a wicked person.

"Traveller, rest here awhile." Traveller, take your rest here. "Whatever you purchase is inexpensive; everything can be found in this place." Nothing you buy will be costly: all things are available. "My mother-in-law is not at home; relatives are far away, and my sister-in-law is innocent by nature." The mother-in-law is absent, other relatives are distant, and the sister-in-law is simple-hearted. "If you turn away despite all this, that will no longer be my doing." If even after this you refuse to stay, I cannot be held responsible. "Says Vidyapati: listen, young woman, you who look to others for fulfilment." Vidyapati addresses the woman and calls upon her to listen. **Scene 3. Vidyapati does not appear in this song. The young woman's sister-in-law is rebuking a traveller; seeing this reminds the woman of her beloved abroad. She addresses the sister-in-law and a female friend in*

song; after each line the friend speaks its meaning. Rāga Dhanachhī *(the Nepalese* Padāvalī*)*: "In foreign lands one must always depend on others; do not turn anyone away, but surely grant shelter." A person far from home depends on the kindness of strangers; a traveller must not be denied a night's lodging. "Friend, understand this much about my beloved." My friend, let this be the lesson of my beloved's situation. "Sister-in-law, judge what is good and bad within your own mind; do not address the traveller with broken, harsh speech." Sister-in-law, consider what is right and wrong, and do not speak roughly to him.

"Wash his feet; offer him a seat; reassure him with words of sweetness." Give him water to wash his feet, a place to sit, and gentle consolation. "Friend, it would be wrong to send him far away; honour him all the more." Friend, sending the traveller elsewhere would be improper: show him greater kindness. **Scene 4. The young woman and her sister-in-law have come to a town and found lodging. A traveller comes seeking shelter. The woman sings, and after each line the sister-in-law interprets it. Four lines are then sung offstage without explanation. The woman resumes, the sister-in-law interprets, and finally Vidyapati appears to sing the last two lines. At the end the sister-in-law asks: "You disliked my rebuking that traveller the other day; why, then, did you refuse this one shelter today?"* Rāga Kolāra* (Vidyapati's songs from Nepal): "I am alone, my beloved is not in the village; I hesitate even to name a place where he might spend the night." I am alone and my husband is away, so I find myself at a loss when asked to provide lodging. "Had anyone lived nearby, I might have pointed him to some other place to stay." If there were a neighbour, I could have directed him there.

> "Forgive me, traveller; what else can I do? Walk through the town and seek shelter elsewhere." Pardon me, traveller, and look for lodging somewhere else in town.
>
> "Open country lies between us, and evening approaches; when staying in a foreign place, consider what may follow." A stretch of lonely land separates us; it is dusk, and a stranger must act with an eye to the future.
>
> "My mind, alas, breaks apart from moment to moment; how long may I hide my youth when desire is awake? Go, go, traveller: what more can I say? Wander through the town and seek another lodging. He prepared those seven or five chambers, then my beloved went far away and distance arose between us. Twelve years were appointed; four years have elapsed since his departure."
>
> "Deep clouds split the darkness of night; weigh carefully whatever you mean to do." Fearsome clouds have gathered: it is a question of the night, and a decision must be made after reflection.

"Says Vidyapati: it is the practice of the town to awaken love through words of indirection." Vidyapati explains that in urban life affection can

arise even from sharp or indirect speech. **Scene 5. Vidyapati does not appear here either. A traveller approaches, but when he sees neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law he feels too embarrassed to lodge and passes on. The young woman sings.* Rāga Ghanachhī *(the Nepalese* Padāvalī*)*: "My dwelling would suit the thief named Desire; an old maidservant stands guard." My circumstances are apt for Love, that thief, while an elderly servant keeps watch.

> "Twelve years were ordained, and four years have passed since he went." His stay had been for twelve years; four years have now elapsed since he left.
>
> "Even the traveller is ashamed to seek shelter; neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law is here to keep me company." Neither relative is present, and the traveller himself is reluctant to ask for lodging.
>
> "He arranged seven or five rooms for Love, then my beloved crossed into another land and a distance came between us." He made the house ready for Kāma, the god of love, and departed abroad, leaving us separated.
>
> "The neighbour's house seems a hundred yojanas away; all relations have scattered to their different places." Even the next dwelling feels a hundred leagues distant, and kin are dispersed everywhere.
>
> "The gathering disappears into the darkness; the neighbour has bolted the gate." People vanish in the night, and the woman next door closes her door.

"My mind flees this way and that; how much longer can I conceal my journey when the god of desire is awake?" I cannot still my mind; passion has awakened, and how long can I hide my intended departure? **Scene 6. Here too neither sister-in-law nor mother-in-law nor Vidyapati is present. A guest arrives just as the rain begins to pour, and the young woman sings.* Rāga Dhanachhī *(the Nepalese* Padāvalī*)*: "I was seated within my own house; there was no other person inside." I was sitting alone at home. "Just then a travelling guest appeared and heaven began to rain." At that very moment the guest arrived and the downpour began.

"Who knows what the spiteful neighbour will say, now she has been given a chance to speak?" I cannot know the words of that jealous woman: an occasion for gossip has been handed to her. "Pitch darkness and unbroken streams of rain turn day itself into night." Even by day it seemed like night. "To whom can I tell my story, and who will believe me, when the five-arrowed god of love is known throughout the world?" What can I say, and whom will I convince, when Kāma's reputation is everywhere known? **Scene 7. At one side of the stage, after the mother-in-law's death, her body is carried out and the lights dim. When the stage becomes bright again, the sister-in-law's husband arrives to take her to her marital home. The traveller moves among the audience. The young woman gestures to the spectators and sings; after each line Vidyapati speaks the meaning. In the final two lines Vidyapati sings both the song and its explanation, repeating*

them several times. From the Padāvalī* edited by Nagendranath Gupta: "My mother-in-law has grown frail and died; my sister-in-law too has gone away to her husband's home." My mother-in-law has passed away; the sister-in-law has left. "Not a soul remains in sight; no one stays awake at night to talk." There is nobody even for conversation. "Such is the custom in this town: not a person asks after another." In this place no one inquires about anyone else. "Tell my beloved how long I, a solitary woman, must remain alone." Ask my husband how many more days I am to live by myself. "Traveller, speak to my lord; how long can the fervour of a woman like me endure?" Tell him how long I can continue in this state. "Sings Vidyapati: the woman afflicted by separation wanders and makes the traveller understand her grief." Vidyapati sings as the separated woman goes from place to place, confiding in the traveller.

As Vidyapati sings, he gradually falls silent. Darkness spreads; a figure becomes visible indistinctly, moving out of the darkness toward the young woman. Is this the beloved who went abroad? Yes—or no?

The atmosphere of *Piyā Desāntar* dissolves; music accompanies the final fall of the curtain.

This conception of *Piyā Desāntar* is offered to thoughtful readers and spectators. In the present suffering of Maithil migrants, it is respectfully dedicated to the great poet Vidyapati.

1. Does the Vidyapati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha speak out of this same pain?

2. The *Padāvalī* bears witness to a parallel culture. A single writer could compose in both Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha, and suffer the scorn of scholars for writing in Avahaṭṭha—but is there even a trace of this particular pain in the Vidyapati of the *Padāvalī*? What we find there is joy and suffering: the joy and suffering of the dispossessed. The Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati—the royal scholar, not a poet of Pali and similar languages—was an erudite man who could be censured even for his Avahaṭṭha compositions. But the Maithili Vidyapati belonged to a parallel tradition far removed from that position. This parallel tradition has existed since the age of the *Ṛgveda*, when *nārāśaṃsī* songs were current. History is silent on whether the Vidyapati of this tradition necessarily belonged to the barber caste or to the Brahmin caste. Yet folklore and inherited practice, the close ties between *Bidāpat* and the dispossessed, and the traditions of Bisfi all point, in my view, to a non-Brahmin identity. No line of the Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭha literature mentions the songs of this Vidyapati; neither do the songs attribute to their author Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭha works. Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha texts lament Muslim invasions and the defilement of the sacred thread and temples, whereas the *Padāvalī*

voices the happiness, vitality, and struggles of the dispossessed. Such lamentation is absent there. When the Brahmin or non-Brahmin identity of the Maithili Vidyapati is itself the question, what outlook are we creating by placing a *pāg* on his head? Would he cease to be "ours" if he were not a Brahmin? Would his migration song, *Piyā Desāntar*, thereby lose its value? Is the exclusive emphasis upon his erotic verses itself a kind of conspiracy? How proper is it to confine a poet like Vidyapati within caste boundaries by making him wear the *pāg*? Vijay Kumar Thakur writes in *Medieval Mithila*: "In Mithila's religious sphere, the influence of the feudal religious ideology of that age was so pervasive that the following remnants of the tradition survive in society even now: ... (d) the *pāg* too is associated with Tantric ideology" (p. 26). Let that headgear, then, be confined to Tantric rites, marriage ceremonies and initiation with the sacred thread. Why mix the Vidyapati of the parallel tradition with those practices? If he belonged to the barber caste, this remains true; if he was a Brahmin, it is all the more true. We can see the rigidity of twenty-first-century Brahminism: if a Brahmin living a thousand years ago was part of the parallel tradition, this feudal survival in the form of a *pāg* should belong to Tantric religious ceremonies, not to the head of Vidyapati.

Mahākavi Vidyapati: an early poet of Maithili who, in this account, preceded Kavīśvara Jyotirishwar (approximately 1275–1350), since Jyotirishwar mentions him in his own work. He is distinguished here from Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha.

Possibly the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur, of the barber caste, from the village of Bisfi.

The *Bidāpat Nāch* of the parallel tradition performs, through music and dance, the poems of Vidyapati's *Padāvalī*—a tradition extending, in this account, to before Jyotirishwar.

Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, 1350–1435: of the Viṣaivāra line, the Bisfi-Kāśyapa branch; a courtier of King Shivasimha and an author in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha. His many enduring works include *Kīrtilatā*, *Kīrtipatākā*, *Puruṣa-Parīkṣā*, *Gorakṣavijaya*, and *Likhanāvalī*. He is distinguished here from the earlier Maithili poet Vidyapati, whom the author places before Jyotirishwar.

Bodhi Kayastha

In Vidyapati Ṭhakkura's *Puruṣa-Parīkṣā* the story of Bodhi Kayastha's attainment of the Ganges is told. The same story of reaching the Ganges also circulated about Mahākavi Vidyapati, the earlier writer of the Maithili

Padāvalī, and later became attached as well to Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha author.

Ugna Mahadeva

Mahadeva, in the guise of Ugna, lived as Vidyapati's servant so that he might hear the poet's songs. This tale of Ugna has become popular through its association with both the earlier Maithili poet Vidyapati, whom the author places before Jyotirishwar, and the later Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, author in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha and courtier of Shivasimha.

2

"The Investiture of Vidyapati with the Sacred Thread and the *Pāg* by the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad"

The Mithila Sanskritik Parishad and those associated with it, including Kishorikant Mishra, either failed to grasp—or did not wish to grasp—the difference between Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, the author in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha, and the poet known as the *Kavikokila*, the cuckoo-voiced Vidyapati. The written historical record places Gonu Jha between 1050 and 1150, yet Usha Kiran Khan depicts him engaging in a learned debate with the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati in her Hindi historical novel *Sirjanhar* (Bharatiya Jnanpith). Virendra Jha places Gonu Jha five hundred years ago, while Taranand Viyogi places him three hundred years ago; their Hindi books on Gonu Jha were published respectively by Rajkamal Prakashan and the National Book Trust. In Vibha Rani's Hindi book on Gonu Jha (Vani Prakashan), Kunal places him during the rule of Bhav Singh, in the fourteenth century. Such is the situation, even though the entries in the *Pañjī* place Gonu Jha ten generations before the Vidyapati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha.

Vidyapati and the Pāg in the Parallel Tradition. Vidyapati's Sanskrit writings bear the words "composed by Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati"; that Vidyapati was a Brahmin. My concern is the poet of the Maithili *Padāvalī*, and the question of why he was made to wear the *pāg* and thereby turned into "our Vidyapati." This did not happen during the eight centuries when non-Brahmin communities preserved him through *Bidāpat Nāch*. Rather, Bengal appropriated the songs of Vidyapati and Govindadas; yet it was the Bengali scholar Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay who first declared, in 1875, that Vidyapati was a poet of Mithila, and it was Nagendranath Gupta, also of Bengal, who first declared Govindadas to be a poet of Mithila. Bengal initially responded with fierce opposition, but eventually accepted the facts.

The Vidyapati whom Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay identified as belonging to Mithila was the Vidyapati of the *Padāvalī*. Bengal never claimed the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati Ṭhakkura as its own.

The Maithili songs inserted into Jyotirishwar's Sanskrit play *Dhūrtasamāgama*, and those included in the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati's *Gorakṣavijaya*, also testify to the older *Padāvalī* tradition and show its influence on both writers.

Then Mithila's scholars grew uneasy. They appealed to Vidyapati's Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha writings and to genealogical-register entries under the names Govindadas and Vidyapati, producing a "Vidyapati Thakur" and a "Govindadas Jha" (!!!). Ramanath Jha's superficial understanding of the *Pañjī* and narrow perspective were damaging here. Then, without warning, a *pāg* was placed on Vidyapati's head: the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, established after India's independence, committed what the author calls the offence of adorning the Maithili poet—not the Sanskrit author—with this headgear and declaring him a Brahmin. Thus the Brahmin establishment made the poet into "our Vidyapati." Yet the *Pañjī* contains many poets, including Kavīśvara Jyotirishwar. Why, then, does the discrepancy between people bearing the name Vidyapati arise here, but not with Jyotirishwar? Although the process was planned, one item of evidence escaped suppression.

Let us return to the *Bidāpat* sung by non-Brahmins. According to this argument, its Vidyapati lived before Jyotirishwar, possibly in the Nāuā Thakur (barber) community. Jyotirishwar's mention of the poet in the *Varṇa-Ratnākara* is advanced as evidence.

Nowhere in the *Padāvalī* does this Vidyapati identify himself as a writer of Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭha. The poems contain compassion for the dispossessed that the writings of the other, Brahmin Vidyapati do not display. Why is this? The Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati, the author argues, expresses contempt for the dispossessed and is a rigid Brahmin in his written statements.

The Vidyapati of the *Padāvalī*, by contrast, is guileless. The author alleges that a few rigidly orthodox passages were absurdly interpolated by Brahminist editors.

The idea behind *Piyā Desāntar*, Vidyapati's *Bidesiya*, has now been placed before informed readers. In the face of the present misery of Maithil migrants, it is respectfully offered to Mahākavi Vidyapati. Does the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati express this pain?

The *Padāvalī* bears witness to a parallel culture. A writer who composed in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha might experience scholars' ridicule for writing in Avahaṭṭha; but is this the pain voiced by the poet of the *Padāvalī*? His songs contain joy and anguish—the joy and anguish of the dispossessed. The Vidyapati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha was a learned royal scholar and could be censured for composing even in Avahaṭṭha; the

Maithili poet, belonging to the parallel tradition, was remote from that situation. This tradition goes back to the *Rgveda*, when *nārāśaṃsī* compositions existed. History is silent on whether this parallel-tradition Vidyapati belonged to the Nāuā Thakur caste or to the Brahmin caste.

Yet the folk narratives and oral traditions, the intimate connection of *Bidāpat* with the dispossessed, and the traditions of Bisfi, are held here to support his non-Brahmin identity. Not a single line of the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha writings mentions the songs of that Vidyapati, nor do the *Padāvalī* songs mention their author's supposed Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭha works. The Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha literature laments Muslim incursions and the desecration of sacred threads and temples; the *Padāvalī*, in contrast, speaks of the delight, vitality and struggle of the dispossessed, without such outcries. In his supposed time, Muslims may scarcely have been resident in Mithila. And when the very question is whether the Maithili Vidyapati was a Brahmin, what mentality are we fostering by dressing him in a *pāg*? Was Vidyapati "ours," or not? If he was not a Brahmin, would he cease to belong to us? Would his migration song *Piyā Desāntar* lose its significance? Is the exclusive discussion of his erotic songs not potentially a conspiracy? How proper is it to imprison a poet of Vidyapati's stature within caste boundaries by making him wear the *pāg*? Vijay Kumar Thakur writes in *Medieval Mithila*: "In Mithila's religious sphere, the influence of the religious ideology of the feudal age was so pervasive that the following remnants of that tradition are still found in society: ... (d) the *pāg* too is connected with Tantric ideology" (p. 26).

Let the *pāg*, then, be confined to Tantric rites, marriage and sacred-thread initiation. Why bring the Vidyapati of the parallel tradition into such ceremonies? It was the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad of Kishorikant Mishra that committed this offence. If the language and culture have nevertheless survived in the care of people claiming to be their guardians, that survival says much about the distinctive strength of the language and culture themselves.

Ramlochan Thakur also made a statement suited to the platform of this same reactionary Kishorikant Mishra, concerning the number of novels, a pronouncement that has no historical value. In the magazine of the Chetana Samiti, Maneshwar Manuj likewise declared in a platform-driven statement that Jagdish Prasad Mandal had written only four novels!!!

If Jagdish Prasad Mandal did not have "Mandal" as a surname and were known simply as Jagdish Prasad, Ramanath Jha's followers would declare him a Śrotriya, Amar and Ramdev Jha's followers would pronounce him a Brahmin, and Mr Verma, author of the *Laldas Memorial Volume*, would proclaim him a Kayastha.

And if Jagdish Prasad Mandal's photograph were unavailable, the reactionary Mithila Sanskritik Parishad of Kishorikant Mishra would perform his sacred-thread investiture, place a *pāg* on his head, and repeat on him the offence it committed against Vidyapati after a thousand years. Some old man in Berma would point to a clod of earth and declare: "Here is the imaginary homestead of Jagdish Prasad Jha/Ṭhakkura."

Abusive remarks from the sons of Malangiya and Ramdev Jha, and from numerous pseudonymous writers, have also been printed without cuts in *Videha*, so that readers may see them. Only abuse that could not be printed has been excluded. Out of fear of abuse, the historians of Maithili and Mithila have thus far hinted at this question but not pursued it further.

Thus, the argument once again concludes that he was a Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishwar (1275–1350). The song-and-dance tradition of Jayadeva (about 1200) and the *kīrtaniyā* tradition correspond with the songs of this earlier Vidyapati, rather than with the poetic style of the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati.

Let us return to the platform of the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, from which Ramlochan Thakur issued his platform-specific declaration. The Parishad did not initiate Vidyapati with the sacred thread; it performed the sacred-thread initiation of Maithili itself. The *pāg* it placed on Vidyapati's head erased Bindhyeshwar Mandal and Shrikant Mandal from Kolkata, and the ritual initiation of Maithili was complete.

Consider an example of the caste rigidity displayed by the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati:

Kīrtilatā: "Marriage across the boundary of caste and non-caste is base and despicable."

In *Puruṣa-Parīkṣā*, while narrating a story, Vidyapati offers an authorial pronouncement that Rajput women lack character. This recalls the statement in the *Atharvaveda* that someone may take a Shudra man's wife by the hand without his consent. The Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati gives exceptional importance to caste and non-caste; purity of blood and birth are central for him. He declares that no person of low lineage deserves compassion!! Beauty, moreover, is supposedly the exclusive possession of the rich and privileged classes!! The Vidyapati in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha—the Vidyapati upon whom Kishorikant Mishra's Mithila Sanskritik Parishad bestowed the sacred thread and *pāg*—maintains that caste is the ultimate determinant of social life. Someone born in a bad family can be nothing but a serpent with an evil mind!! The same writer states that a country without enforceable caste rules is a land of *mlecchas*, outsiders or barbarians (Upendra Thakur, *Aspects of Society and Economy of Medieval Mithila*).

I have found no description of the *pāg* earlier than Amir Khusrau.

But the earlier Vidyapati, whom the author identifies as the writer of the *Padāvalī* before Jyotirishwar, says: "The king punishes no one here."

"The men of consequence are all of my own kind."

Hence the ruler does not punish anybody, and all the great and powerful people are of the same kind.

Govindadas's verses were difficult and did not possess a parallel living tradition, perhaps because they circulated among the upper castes. For those reasons they could not be preserved in this soil as *Bidāpat Nāch* was. What became of the poems of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, whom Vardhamāna called *Sukavi-kairava-kānana-induḥ*, the moon over a grove of water lilies that are excellent poets? Pakṣadhara imposed a ban on writing, yet Raghunatha Shiromani and his disciples "Udayana" and "Gaṅgeśa" continued by memorizing works; with the establishment of the Navya-Nyāya school at Navadvipa, students stopped coming from Bengal.

The Vidyapati placed before Jyotirishwar: Abhinavagupta of Kashmir, who lived at the end of the tenth and beginning of the eleventh century, is said to mention Vidyapati in his *Īśvara-Pratyabhijñā-Vimarśinī*.

In Śrīdhara Dāsa's *Saduktikarṇāmṛta*, five verses of Vidyapati are quoted, in the language of the Vidyapati *Padāvalī*.

"So long as the mālatī does not unfold its blossom,"
"The bee will not sport with its honey."

And

"Where is the nectar of a bud whose petals remain closed?"

(*Medieval Mithila*, Upendra Thakur)

Jyotirishwar (1275–1350), Sixth *Kallola*, "Description of Learned People": "The Bidāpat entered the court; following him came a Telugu woman and a Maratha woman. The two women associated with the Bidāpat looked as though they had bathed in the two-coloured waters of the Ganges and Yamuna. Each wore a garment with four hanging ends … How did they appear? As the Saraswati joins the Ganges and Yamuna at Prayag, so the two attendants stood beside the Bidāpat. Daśaundhī announced to the king: 'Let the Bidāpat take his place in court.'"

(The Bidāpat, a man, entered. Behind him came a Telugu woman and a Maratha woman. The two women looked as though they had bathed in the differently coloured Ganges and Yamuna. Each wore a garment with four ends. Imagine how they looked: just as the Saraswati is joined by the

Ganges and Yamuna at Prayag, the two women stood on either side of the Bidāpat. Daśaundhī informed the king, and the Bidāpat took his seat.)

Eighth *Kallola*, "Description of the Realm": "The songs of the Bidāpats, their dancing, instruments and rhythm, with their long, flowing skirts ..."

The Bidāpat performers sang, danced and played instruments in time, wearing their long skirts.

Ugna Mahadeva. Mahadeva lived in Vidyapati's house as a servant, under the name Ugna, to hear the poet's songs. This tale of Ugna became famous through its association with both the earlier Maithili Vidyapati, whom the author places before Jyotirishwar, and Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing courtier of Shivasimha.

Bodhi Kayastha. The story of Bodhi's attainment of the Ganges is told in the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati Ṭhakkura's *Puruṣa-Parīkṣā*. The tale also circulated about the earlier Mahākavi Vidyapati of the Maithili *Padāvalī*, and later became attached to Vidyapati Ṭhakkura as well.

Vidyapati Ṭhakkura's Sanskrit writings came to prominence after Mithila's learned tradition had declined. His work receives little particular attention within Sanskrit literary history, and fewer students were coming from Bengal. For those who did arrive, his Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha compositions were contemporary works produced while the older scholarly tradition was dying, whereas the pre-Jyotirishwar *Padāvalī* had already become famous. It is not even certain that the *pāg* existed in Gonu Jha's or Vidyapati's time, since the author finds its mention only in Amir Khusrau (1253–1325). Vijay Kumar Thakur regards it as a feudal symbol associated with Tantric practices. It may have been imposed upon subordinate chiefs after Muslim incursions; it also resembles a Muslim cap. Following those incursions, according to this account, only Brahmins and Kayasthas—not Rajputs—held feudal authority in Mithila; among those two groups the headgear is sometimes still used at weddings and other ceremonies.

Mahākavi Vidyapati. The first poet of Maithili, placed here before Kavīśvara Jyotirishwar (about 1275–1350), because Jyotirishwar's work mentions him. He is distinguished from Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha author. According to tradition, he may have been the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur of the Nāuā Thakur (barber) community in Bisfi. The *Bidāpat Nāch* of the parallel tradition has performed his *Padāvalī* poems in song and dance since before Jyotirishwar's time.

Vidyapati Ṭhakkura, 1350–1435: belonging to the Viṣaivāra, Bisfi-Kāśyapa branch; a courtier of King Shivasimha, and a Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha writer. His many lasting works include *Kīrtilatā*, *Kīrtipatākā*, *Puruṣa-*

Parīkṣā, *Gorakṣavijaya*, and *Likhanāvalī*. The author distinguishes him from the earlier Maithili poet Vidyapati, placed before Jyotirishwar.

3

Phanishwarnath Renu wrote a reportage on *Bidāpat Nāch*, published in the weekly *Vishwamitra* on 1 August 1945. The reportage is important because it was written seven hundred years after Jyotirishwar's account of the same subject; throughout those seven centuries, the parallel tradition kept Vidyapati alive. Yet Vidyapati was suddenly taken away from the people who had kept him alive. Bideshwar Thakur died singing Vidyapati's songs and protesting that the Brahmins had taken the poet away by placing a *pāg* upon his head. Kanungo Badri Prasad Thakur of Brahmpura, Vinod Thakur of Pokharbhira, Saryug Thakur of Rudrapur, Jayaram Thakur of Mehath, and the whole village of Bisfi continue to repeat this lament. Shaligram Yadav and Awadhiya Thakur are witnesses to Bisfi's tradition. All kinds of fanciful arguments concerning Vidyapati's birth have been advanced in the course of this ritual appropriation, but no research paper has even discussed his parallel tradition. This essay is dedicated to the thousands of people of that tradition, people like Bideshwar Thakur who kept Vidyapati alive between Jyotirishwar's account and Phanishwarnath Renu's reportage.

Mithila's Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa tradition and its parallel tradition.
Language must have existed before the *Ṛgveda*, the oldest surviving work of Vedic Sanskrit. A considerable body of oral literature—*gāthā*, *nārāśaṃsī*, tales of deities and other narratives—must already have been composed. The *Ṛgveda* employs the terms *gāthin*, *gātuvit* and *gāthapati* for singers of such narratives. From the Vedic period onward, *gāthā* and *nārāśaṃsī* existed side by side. Did Vedic Sanskrit develop out of Prakrit, or did Prakrit develop out of Vedic Sanskrit? The people's narratives called *nārāśaṃsī* in the Veda indicate that the two continued in parallel for a long time, each influencing the other. Consider the *Ṛgveda*: what does the use of *dūlabha* in place of *durlabha* (4.9.8) demonstrate? What does *paścā* in place of *paścāt* in the *Atharvaveda* (10.4.10) suggest? And what does *pratisaṃhāya* for *pratisaṃdhāya* in the *Gopatha Brāhmaṇa* (2.4) show?

The Aryans came to Mithila from the western part of India, and parts of the Vedas existed before they arrived. That is why so many Maithili words and pronunciations occur in Vedic Sanskrit but not in classical Sanskrit. Ignorance, the theory of karma, the round of birth and rebirth, and liberation are concepts, the author argues, that the Aryans received from non-Aryans. Hence the Upanishads teach a path to liberation, not merely to heaven. How is liberation obtained? Through sacrifice? No: through knowledge, reflection, contemplation and meditation. Under the

patronage of King Janaka, Yājñavalkya composed the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* in Tirhut, a region characterized here as non-Aryan.

Commenting on the fifty-seventh aphorism of the *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, Vācaspati Miśra asks whether it can be said that unconscious milk nourishes a calf and, correspondingly, that unconscious nature directs a living being toward liberating knowledge. God is complete in himself: for what purpose would he create the world? If he created it out of compassion for living beings, those beings would be bound only after creation; before creation there was no bondage, so what occasion could there have been for compassion? Creation therefore occurs through *prakṛti*, and the living being obtains *apavarga*, liberation, by its own effort. Dissolution too occurs through discrimination. The author's reading of Vācaspati is thus non-theistic, not theistic. If God took part in directing nature, that would be a conscious act undertaken for a purpose; God has no such need. Gautama of Mithila, composer of the *Nyāyasūtra*, speaks of attaining the supreme good through knowledge of sixteen categories, but nowhere among those categories does he say that liberation is attained through God. The *Vaiśeṣikasūtra* says the Vedas were composed by learned people, not by God. Kumārila Bhaṭṭa holds that reliable discussion of God's existence before creation is impossible.

The so-called mainstream of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa and its parallel mainstream. Brahminism and non-Brahminism existed in Mithila from the beginning. Jyotirishwar writes, "The Buddhist side appears thus: fearsome at first sight." Because of a similarity of names, the inert tradition of the *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* has been eager to sanctify the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati. Vedic *ṛc* and *nārāśaṃsī*, Mahākavi Vidyapati and the *pāg*-wearing Vidyapati, liberation and heaven or hell: these opposed ways of thinking have coexisted in Mithila. Both Videgha Māthava of the *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* and Nimi of the Purāṇas are said to have a priest named Gautama; the author identifies them and locates the beginning of the Videha kingdom here. Māthava's priest Gautama inaugurated the *Mitravinda* sacrifice or offering, which Yājñavalkya later restored in the time of Mahājanaka II. The tradition that continually invoked Maitreyi, Yājñavalkya, Sita and Janaka was able to perform Vidyapati's sacred-thread investiture and install the *pāg* with extraordinary speed; that course of action accorded with its supposed *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* mainstream.

After the decree of Madhav Singh's branch of the *Pañjī* in 1760, a new ideology of elite lineage spread among Brahmins and Kayasthas in Mithila. The *bhalmānus* or *battēsagamiyā* subdivision emerged among Karna Kayasthas and the Śrotriya subdivision among Maithil Brahmins. The

author associates these developments with severe increases in physical and mental illness in both groups, along with polygamy, child marriage and the number of widows. The speed and quietness with which this took place also suited the supposed mainstream of the *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa*.

The views of Dineshwar Lal Anand and Ramvriksha Benipuri on Vidyapati!! Dineshwar Lal Anand was mistaken. At that time the *Pañjī* was a secret body of records, and the Viṣaivāra Bisfi line of the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati had been reclassified in the registers as Jayavara, a lower grade. The branch registers did not exist before 1760. Evidence of this, the author contends, is that descendants of Ayachi Mishra's original line appear in both the Śrotriya and other Brahmin subdivisions. It is rather like the Indus Valley seals: they show bulls, but not cows—how then could bulls have appeared without cows? Anand did not have access to every fact in the registers. Perhaps, influenced by the misrepresentation that the *Padāvalī* poet and the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati were one and the same, he thought that connecting the Jayavara classification of the Viṣaivāra Bisfi line with the writer's use of Avahaṭṭha would explain why Vidyapati Ṭhakkura became a revolutionary. Anand nevertheless admits that not even an autograph of the *Padāvalī*, nor a record of its collection during Vidyapati's lifetime, is available. But how could that be, when the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati announced the beginnings and endings of his books so emphatically, identifying the kings and queens who inspired him and the patrons under whose protection he lived? The full apparatus of literary authorship is there, with the strength of both Saraswati and Lakshmi. Why is it absent from the *Padāvalī*? Anand remains silent. The Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati identifies his patrons but writes almost nothing about himself in those books. He feels pressured even in writing Avahaṭṭha, which was then a literary language of the dominant tradition. Yet the earlier Vidyapati's influence was so great that he had to insert Maithili songs into his Sanskrit drama *Gorakṣavijaya*, just as Jyotirishwar, who wrote the first reportage on the Bidāpat, had included Maithili songs in his Sanskrit *Dhūrtasamāgama*.

Govind Jha recognises the Vidyapati tradition in Jyotirishwar's Bidāpat and discusses it. Why, however, can he not carry that recognition back to a pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati, while Bideshwar Thakur is literally singing his life away? How can the place in a play where Vidyapati felt thirsty become the home village of the playwright? Everyone is writing plays about "our Vidyapati" according to personal convenience.

Ramvriksha Benipuri too lacked the evidence of the *Pañjī*. On the basis of a fabricated caste subdivision and an anecdote he wrote a satirical piece on

Keshav Mishra's Vidyapati. This Keshav Mishra of the *Dvaita Pariśiṣṭa* was the grandson of Vācaspati II (1400–1490). Another Keshav Mishra, living around 1150, wrote the *Tarkabhāṣā*; Vardhamāna, son of Gaṅgeśa, composer of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, reviewed it in his *Tarkaprakāśa*. Benipuri could not advance even one step beyond the research Ananda Coomaraswamy had undertaken in 1915; nor has any other mainstream scholar advanced beyond it a hundred years later. Benipuri retells the Ugna story but is silent on whether Mahadeva would dance on Kailasa to the Brahminical Vidyapati's *Śaivasarvasvasāra* or to the *nācārī* songs of the earlier Vidyapati. Like Coomaraswamy, Benipuri knew that a manuscript of the *Bhāgavata* written in the hand of the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati was available, and had heard that Vidyapati attained the Ganges and was taken into the river's embrace. Like Coomaraswamy, however, he had heard of the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati's *Puruṣa-Parīkṣā* without reading it. Otherwise he would have known that Vidyapati tells that story of Bodhi Kayastha. The Ganges tale, like the story of Ugna, had circulated in connection with the earlier Vidyapati before it was transferred ritually to the later Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha writer; the story of Bodhi Kayastha in *Puruṣa-Parīkṣā* is cited as evidence. Benipuri even calls *Kīrtipatākā* a collection of Maithili songs!! Is inquiry by hearsay to be called research? Why has the withered mainstream failed to go beyond the foundation laid by Coomaraswamy a hundred years earlier? Because, the author says, its Śatapatha-Brahminical mainstream will not allow it. Yet without evidence Benipuri declares Puraditya, a friend of Shivasimha, a Bhumihar Brahmin, just as Ramanath Jha called Govindadas (Jha) a Śrotriya—a claim Sukumar Sen considered ridiculous —Ramdev Jha declared him a Brahmin, and Mr Verma, in the *Laldas Memorial Volume*, pronounced Kalidasa a Kayastha.

The Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati begins and ends his books with full ritual observances; he remembers kings, queens and patrons, but says nothing about himself. Why did the *Padāvalī* live on in people's voices? Why was it not furnished with the elaborate literary framing of his books? Because, in this account, the songs were composed centuries before him, at a time when the *pāg* had not yet appeared in Mithila. Names such as Rupnarayan, Shivasimha, Lakhima, Dev Singh, Har Singh, Padam Singh, Vishwas Deve, Arjun-Amar, Raghav Singh, Rudra Singh, Dhir Singh, Bhairav Singh and Chandra Singh were later inserted into the songs; their insertion is clearly perceptible in disruptions of the melody. The Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati's *Bhūparikramā* (for Dev Singh), *Kīrtilatā* (for Kirti Singh and Vir Singh), *Kīrtipatākā*, *Gorakṣavijaya* (for Shivasimha), *Likhanāvalī* (for Puraditya) and *Dānavākyāvalī* (for Queen Dhirmati) were plainly works composed under royal patronage. *Gorakṣavijaya* was written for a Bhairava worship

ceremony; like *Dhūrtasamāgama*, it contained Maithili songs, demonstrating the immense influence of the earlier Vidyapati. Were their names not identical, someone would have turned Jyotirishwar himself into a Vidyapati who lived before Jyotirishwar.

Gaṅgeśa, author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, wrote one work equivalent, it is said, to twelve thousand books. Professor Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in *History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila*: "The family which was inferior in social status is now extinct in Mithila … Gangesha's family is completely ignored and we are not expected to know even his father's name." He adds that this information was provided by Professor R. Jha—that is, Ramanath Jha!

Let us examine what the genealogical registers say. They clearly record, the author contends, that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death and married a woman of the leatherworking community. Why did Ramanath Jha conceal these facts from Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya? A caste subdivision spread the story of Gaṅgeśa's transformation from fool to scholar, and a conspiracy was formed to erase him. Gaṅgeśa's son Vardhamāna called his father *Sukavi-kairava-kānana-induḥ*. The foregoing examples, the author argues, show the kind of conspiracy through which the poetry of so celebrated a scholar has become unavailable.

Vasudeva of Bengal was a fellow student of Pakṣadhara Miśra. He came to Mithila for study, passed the *śalākā* examination, and received the title Sārvabhauma. Vasudeva memorised the verses of Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* and Udayana's *Nyāyakusumāñjali*. Pakṣadhara and the other teachers of Mithila would not allow the *Tattvacintāmaṇi* to be written down or copied! Raghunatha Shiromani, Vasudeva's disciple, defeated his teacher Pakṣadhara Miśra in disputation and secured the right to reproduce the text. Vasudeva and Raghunatha established a Navya-Nyāya school at Navadvipa. Pakṣadhara Miśra was a contemporary of the Vidyapati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha; with Raghunatha, the arrival of students from Bengal to Mithila came to an end.

Grierson called the Bisfi copperplate said to have been given by Shivasimha to the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati a forgery, because Grierson knew the *Padāvalī* and thought it impossible that its poet should have received such a grant. Yet the copperplate had actually been given, according to the argument here, to the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati. Grierson did not consider the difference between the two. Mahāmahopādhyāya Haraprasad Shastri did consider it and judged the copperplate genuine.

Śrīdhara Dāsa's *Saduktikarṇāmṛta* contains a hymn to the Ganges by the Kaivarta Papiha, and songs of Radha and Krishna. Dhoyi, a court poet of Lakshman Sen, was a *jolhā* (weaver). Lakhima Thakurain did not compose *Padāvalī* songs but wrote verse in Sanskrit, according to Grierson. Śrīdhara Dāsa's inscription is at Andhratharhi, and he served as minister to Nanyadeva and Gangadeva. His descendant Amiyakar lived at the time of the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭha-writing Vidyapati. Upendra Thakur considers Gangadeva a Kalachuri ruler. Vijay Kumar Thakur reads a Vidyapati song in Śrīdhara Dāsa's *Saduktikarṇāmṛta* as a eulogy of the Kalachuri Karna. Radhakrishna Chaudhary differs. In any event, this Vidyapati lived before Jyotirishwar. According to the *Rāmacarita*, Vigrahapala III defeated Karna; Radhakrishna Chaudhary found two Pala inscriptions at Naulagarh, sixteen kilometres north of Begusarai, bearing upon that struggle. That Karna too belonged to the eleventh century. *Dhūrtasamāgama* is also well known in South India.

Appendix:

Phanishwarnath Renu

A Vidyapati of Folk Song
Introduction

While researching Mahākavi Vidyapati, I felt that one chapter would need to be entitled "Vidyapati, Poet of the Cultivators, Sowers and Bullock-Cart Drivers." For even today, in the Purnia-Saharsa region, there are troupes that sing Vidyapati's songs and dance while expressing their emotions. The leaders of these troupes are often buffalo-riders, herdsmen and drivers of carts. I asked the scholars of Mithila about this.

"How could this have happened?" They replied, "What sort of trouble have you got yourself into? These fools are the reason Vidyapati is in such a condition today. These ordinary people took it into their heads to tack on four or so songs in Vidyapati's name ... You are being led astray." Paying no attention to the prohibitions of Mithila's scholars, I cheerfully began preparing for a journey to Saharsa—or should that be Saharsha? Kanchira is a village over which two district magistrates exercise authority: half the village lies in Saharsa and half in Purnia. The Vidyapati troupe of Kanchira is known to people in both districts. On the day I reached the village, something unusual had happened there. A leader who had represented the area for ten years had been defeated outright in an election. A performance of song and dance that night might therefore have been given another political meaning. Fearing this, Janakdas, leader of the Vidyapati troupe, refused permission for a performance.

On the second night, after much persuasion, he gave permission. After prolonged argument, returning repeatedly to the point, Janakdas asserted that "Vidyapati dance" had first originated in his own family. He would never explain further. When he finally became convinced that I had not come to obtain one or two thousand rupees from the government treasury in the name of his "Vidyapati Dance Troupe," he struck the *mṛdaṅga*. I watched the dancing all night. A boy who normally tended cattle, dressed in a sari, became Radha, a woman tormented by separation, and sang in tears: "How many days, Hari, must I send you away, I, a solitary woman?" The next day I asked Janakdas about the origin of the dance. He said, "I do not know how long its original songs have continued in our family." His unhappiness was caused by my tape recorder. "You secretly put all the songs on your tape, slyly! You got your work done for free, did you?" Even after I paid him fifty rupees in cash, he would not answer my question: when and how had cultivators, field-workers, herdsmen and cart drivers begun to dance while singing Vidyapati's songs? I lay all day on the straw in Janakdas's thatched shelter, but he took no pity. His widowed young daughter pleaded my case, but he still would not relent. "Do you want to have our family's joke printed in the Government Gazette?" The old Janakdas released his oxen and went to graze them. I remained lying in his shelter, and only afterwards heard a story—or dreamed it, or fell into some illusion. I cannot say which.

39. Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār', Known as the Bhikhari Thakur of Maithili: The First People's Poet of Maithili, His Songs and Jhārū — 'Without Me, the World Is Empty'

Abstract

The 'Bhikhari Thakur of Maithili', Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār', challenges the world and declares, 'Without me, the world is empty.' Have we ever heard of a poetic genre called jhārū ('broom') in Maithili literature—or indeed in the literature of any language—apart from Mandal's jhārū? For the new form that Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār' has invented spontaneously, on a buffalo's back, along the embankments and ridges of fields, and at crossroads, is meant to sweep away society's vices with a rough broom.

Keywords: Maithili; Bhikhari Thakur; renowned as; first people's poet; Ramdev.

The 'Bhikhari Thakur of Maithili', Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār', challenges the world and says, 'Without me, the world is empty.' Have we heard of a poetic genre called *jhārū* ('broom') in Maithili

literature, or in the literature of any other language, apart from Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār's' *jhārū*? Of course not!
For the new genre that Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār' has spontaneously invented on a buffalo's back, along field embankments and dusty ridges, and at crossroads is designed to scour society's vices away with a coarse broom. A flower-broom will not sweep a threshing floor, just as a rough field-broom cannot be used to sweep a veranda. A broom of pigeon-pea stalks fastened to a stick clears away the refuse. Thus there are many kinds of brooms and scraping brushes in everyday use. Ramdev writes songs, and also *jhārū* in many colours and varieties, like the many-coloured *panisokhā*. Each problem calls for its own broom. And when both older and newer writers of Maithili increasingly adopt surnames derived from clan and lineage, how much does the pen-name 'Jhārūdār'—the wielder of the broom—communicate without a further word?
And consider the poet's self-confidence: without me, there is nothing.
Before me there was no rule.
Nor was there any ordinance of religion.
Without me the world is empty.
The one who would kill is no better than a beast.
Now seek out, if you will, the Buddhist philosophy of emptiness and Śaṅkara's Advaita in this *jhārū*!
He wants neither the disease of money nor the disease of superstition.
Everyone has become sick with the hunger for money,
Devotees of superstition and harmful custom.
But do we need Rāma's bow and arrows to remedy this? That would mean waiting for Rāma to be born again. No: trust yourself. For if you are the problem, you are also the solution.
Who but you will take away this suffering?
It is through you that all these demons will die.
Make the pen, once more,
Rāma's bow and arrows, my friends.
The poet understands the importance of unity among people. But how is unity to be achieved? Observe his answer:
To forge unity, one must endure;
One must flow together, joining vessel to vessel;
One must bend when one is in the wrong.
The condition of women—whether a woman remains in her village or has become a political leader—still causes pain. When the poet is Jhārūdār, that hurt finds expression in this manner:
Women bear within them Sītā and Rādhā;
Men have turned into Rāvaṇa and Kaṃsa.
How then can this household,
This world of human relationships, survive?
But what is the remedy? Will men change the condition of women? No:

women themselves possess the necessary confidence. They will grasp the thread of education, and then—
No longer shall women remain ignorant;
They will become resolute, strong, and unyielding.
Does the poet concern himself only with women's condition, caste and similar social questions? Not at all. He is also troubled by pollution, that product of scientific and technological development:
Pollution, this gift of science,
Has entered the home like a rat.
It stands with its mouth agape like a tiger;
The world has become its prey.
And he also shows the younger generation how pollution may be reduced:
Let the engine be in perfect condition;
Let it emit no needless smoke.
Think a little of the next generation:
How will it build its world?
He has written a *jhārū* on this theme too. He asks us to protect not merely the forests but those who live in them:
Forests, lakes, rivers and forest-dwellers,
Mountains and plateaus, together with deserts—
Protect the environment;
In this way the country will become prosperous.
On dowry and the *kāṭar* custom, Ramdev writes:
Today Sītā weeps in every home;
All night long Janaka cannot sleep.
Where will the money for dowry come from?
How will a daughter be given in marriage?
Jhārūdār is proud of Mithila. But of which Mithila?
Where the world-purifying Gaṅgā flows, where the jyotirliṅga shines;
Where the teachings of Hazrat, Tulsī and Vālmīki resound.
Yet Jhārūdār worries about Mithila as it exists within Bihar. He wishes to show something to Bihar's Chief Minister Nitish Kumar, who is called a 'son of development':
I shall take photographs with my camera
Of Mithila and its Maithil families;
I shall go to Patna to show them
To Nitish Kumar, the 'son of development'.
I shall photograph fields without irrigation,
Deprived of irrigation water and electricity.
Where does humanity reside? In human beings, surely. And it is such a person who will win the world's crown and live victoriously as Jhārūdār!
May I receive the crown of the entire world,
And live as Jhārūdār;
If humanity lives in human beings,

Their true nature will never change.
Thus the *jhārū* and songs composed while wandering through woods, scrubland, fields and open countryside must surely be distinctive, and the one who wrote them deserves that crown. Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur will indeed wear it and bear the name Jhārūdār.

Supplementary Discussion

The 'Bhikhari Thakur of Maithili', Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār', challenges the world and says, 'Without me, the world is empty.'

Have we heard of a poetic genre called *jhārū* ('broom') in Maithili literature, or in the literature of any other language, apart from Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jhārūdār's' *jhārū*? Of course not!

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Does the poet concern himself only with women's condition, caste and similar social questions? Not at all. He is also troubled by pollution, that product of scientific and technological development:

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May I receive the crown of the entire world,
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If humanity lives in human beings,
Their true nature will never change.

Thus the *jhārū* and songs composed while wandering through woods, scrubland, fields and open countryside must surely be distinctive, and the one who wrote them deserves that crown. Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur will indeed wear it and bear the name Jhārūdār.

40. Ramvilas Sahu's Collection of Poems, Songs, Haiku, Senryū and Tanka, *Rathak Chakkā Ulaṭi Chalai Bāṭ* ('The Chariot Wheel Travels Against the Road')

Abstract

Rathak Chakkā Ulaṭi Chalai Bāṭ is the title of Ramvilas Sahu's collection of poems, songs, haiku, senryū and tanka. Employing an unadulterated vernacular vocabulary, he expresses his love of nature in three-line haiku and senryū and five-line tanka. His emotional response brings so many facts to light, discovers so many problems and searches for so many solutions, that readers may exclaim: 'Yes, why

did I not think of this? But now I shall be able to.' Does Sahu's following tanka not remind us of Japan's Bashō?

Keywords: Ramvilas Sahu; poetry; song; haiku; senryū; tanka.

Rathak Chakkā Ulaṭi Chalai Bāṭ is the title of Ramvilas Sahu's collection of poems, songs, haiku, senryū and tanka. Employing the genuine vocabulary of the countryside, he conveys his love of nature through three-line haiku and senryū and five-line tanka. His poetry reveals so many facts, identifies so many difficulties and searches for their remedies with such feeling that readers may say: 'Yes, why did I not think of that? Now I shall be able to.'

The chariot's wheel
Travels against the path;
The potter's wheel spins,
Dancing where it stands—
Each wheel performs its different work.

Does the following tanka by Ramvilas Sahu not call to mind Japan's Bashō?

The month of Sāvan;
Drops of water fall
From the sky.
The frogs' instruments sound;
Ditches and hollows fill with water.

How wonderful the meeting of human life and nature seems in his poetry:

Black kohl,
Disfiguring a face;
The black cuckoo
Sings a sweet song
And enchants everyone.

But the comparison with black kohl does not end there:

Black kohl
May dry out the eyes;
Dark clouds
May drown us in rain,
And spoil our faces.

The nature-loving poet has read the properties of the sun well. Is this any less a description of the seasons than those of spring and winter?

The sunlight of Chaitra
Heats earth and water;

The westerly wind
Ripens gram and wheat,
And sweeps up dust and grit.

The poet is no less accomplished in longer verse; the current of the Kosi stirs him deeply:

My life has turned impoverished;
Jhauā, reeds, *kāś* and *khagrā* grasses contend with me;
The lives of my children have been swallowed by the floodwaters.

The poet also turns his pen against superstition:

The goddess's spirit dances through male and female mediums;
Thirty-six goddesses and fourteen gods
Have supposedly entered your body this very moment.
Whatever you ask for, they will grant;
They will remove every illness and affliction;
They will bless you with flowers and consecrated rice;
Failed undertakings and cherished wishes
They will fulfil in the snap of a finger;
In return they will demand *laddus*, goats and kids.

The poet is a farmer: how could he forget agriculture?

From early morning the fields
Begin to turn to muddy slush;
The ploughman drives his plough
While singing *birhā* songs.

And then …

'On the destruction of the plough
And the cultivation of the field
Rest all our hopes
Of filling our stomachs.'

And then …

I filled the granary with wheat grain;
I piled the chaff in the chaff-house.
The wheat crop of four months
I brought home through labour day and night;
With bread to eat, we shall live all year.

Through the words of village life and its sayings and proverbs, the poet communicates a great deal:

Rice bought in the market, water drawn along the road—

The merchant's household scales
Carry no value or worth.

For ...

The market's rice was lost on the way;
The water at the river landing dried up there.

The poet also knows about indigenous remedies and the prevention of disease:

Whoever eats a chutney of *ichnā* and *poṭhī* fish,
Along with bread made of finger millet,
Will not grow ill or fat—
From high blood pressure, diabetes or dropsy.

Ramvilas Sahu sings (and writes) *chaitāvar* songs, listens to *birhā*, and composes poetry on rice transplantation and farming. It would be difficult to find a match in literature for his poems on all these subjects. They have expanded the range of Maithili poetry. Ramvilas Sahu possesses not merely the ability to write about these matters but the ability to enter into their inner life and write from within.

Gajendra Thakur

Supplementary Discussion

Rathak Chakkā Ulaṭi Chalai Bāṭ is the title of Ramvilas Sahu's collection of poems, songs, haiku, senryū and tanka. Employing the genuine vocabulary of the countryside, he conveys his love of nature through three-line haiku and senryū and five-line tanka. His poetry reveals so many facts, identifies so many difficulties and searches for their remedies with such feeling that readers may say: 'Yes, why did I not think of that? Now I shall be able to.'

Does the following tanka by Ramvilas Sahu not call to mind Japan's Bashō?

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Ramvilas Sahu sings (and writes) *chaitāvar* songs, listens to *birhā*, and composes poetry on rice transplantation and farming. It would be difficult to find a match in literature for his poems on all these subjects. They have expanded the range of Maithili poetry. Ramvilas Sahu possesses not merely the ability to write about these matters but the ability to enter into their inner life and write from within.

41. Umesh Mandal's *Nishtuki*: A Collection of Poems, Short Poems, Haiku, Tanka and Ghazals

Abstract

Nishtuki is a collection of poems, short poems, haiku, tanka and ghazals by Umesh Mandal. The new generation of Maithili writers does not wish to accord respect to age alone when that age is not progressive. And this is how it should be: it is work that merits respect, not age or inherited standing.

Keywords: Umesh · Mandal · Nishtuki · poetry · short poem · haiku · tanka

Nishtuki is Umesh Mandal's collection of poems, short poems, haiku, tanka and ghazals. Maithili's new generation does not want to confer prestige merely on the basis of age if the elder in question is not progressive. Nor should it: work deserves respect, not age or inherited rank. Why, then, should elderly people or established figures who are progressive not receive their due respect?

Consider this tanka:

> The problem, the venerable elder—
> Adorned in all sixteen ornaments,
> The man of letters;
> The elder seems old in his writing:
> How will reality ever arrive?

And so, in the short poem "In Old Age," he says:

> Life wants to act;
> It shows us the path of work.

Once we take the path of action, we must keep sounding out our protest:

> From a tiny hole into a burden,
> Gathering the scattered earth,
> Dissatisfaction again and again—
> The hollow trunk goes on smouldering.

Migration from Mithila continues, and it wounds the poet again and again. But when spring arrives, will a philosophical recognition not arrive with it?

> Spring has come;
> I shall go to the village.
> Here, now,
> I can remain no longer.
> In search of spring itself

I have been wandering.
From this migration:
At the village threshold
A forest has grown.

Again and again, fissures appear in the poet's thinking:

Your words,
My mind—
The two meet;
Together they are entangled,
Searching for spring.
But
The bird of spring—
I do not wish to keep it beside me.

He is beginning to understand:

In that pitch-dark room—

And he asks you:

How, then, will it appear in the mirror?
How will its image emerge?

And no one wants to hear the song in which nothing is being sung but the song of culture:

That rushing, buzzing voice—
No one is prepared to listen.

Why is no one prepared to listen? Because there is fear: afraid of pain, they do not wish to hear that rushing, buzzing voice.

Certain strange things make him uneasy:

Fire and water,
The measure of the mind.

There is a reason, too. Consider the image of the incendiary:

Swearing an oath, the god of death,
A companion as people's houses burn.

Knowledge, the learned, and even the light of knowledge sometimes leave him caught in confusion:

Even knowledge becomes a slave;
Sankrityayan comes to mind with a thud.

Even the corpse you thought you understood will now speak:

Now it will speak;

Speaking, it will laugh
At your creations,
At the culture you have made.

Mangal and Mangala appear in several places in his poems. Mangala is a symbol of helplessness.

Mangala stands aside,
And further on ...
She has made herself solitary.

At the dry river landing, look at Mangala's helplessness before the keeper of the ghat:

He will demand the fare at the dried-up landing;
If we do not pay, he will raise an outcry.
Thus it happened: Mangala turned back,
And faced towards the west.

The poet brings in the image of the potter's craft in this way:

Like an image made of unfired clay,
It is called nothing but a frame;
Likewise the fruit formed from a flower
Is called merely the first hard growth.
And that very first growth
Goes on holding fast to hope,
Enduring sun and wind.

And he comes upon other travellers like himself:

These travellers, too, are like me;
They want to advance along a lost path.

The poet has no illusion: the path one takes determines the landing one reaches, and the water there will answer to that landing:

As the path of walking is,
So is the path of understanding;
Whatever road a person takes,
That is the landing they will reach.

The same path and way of thinking recur in another poem:

If one walks with thought,
No one can prevent one from reaching the landing.

His pen also explores how someone takes a good or a bad road:

As the people of a house are,
So is the threshold of that house;

As the threshold of a house is,
So is the path it takes.

The road does not leave him even in a later ghazal:

The fair woman, blinded by pride, stood stubbornly;
The road looks dark—come, let us turn back.

He never entirely surrenders to despair:

Even in death, taking blow upon blow,
I call it a wisdom beaten into us.

And the reason, as he says, is this:

Just as water rises when it finds its course,
Even a dead current comes to life.
Though in the midst of the victorious current,
It may be called a mere three-masua stream.

Amid hope, anger and despondency, he writes:

Leave it alone and society will break apart;
If our Umesh joins it together, it seems it will blossom.

Whatever Umesh Mandal says, he says it *nishtuki*—plainly and without evasions. Confusion, entanglement and disorder lie scattered all around him. But he works to straighten them out rather than deepen the tangle.

Gajendra Thakur

Supplementary Discussion

Once we take the path of action, we must keep sounding out our protest:

Migration from Mithila continues, and it wounds the poet again and again. But when spring arrives, will a philosophical recognition not arrive with it?

From this migration:

Again and again, fissures appear in the poet's thinking:

Even the corpse you thought you understood will now speak:

The road does not leave him even in a later ghazal:

Leave it alone and society will break apart.

42. Umesh Paswan's Poetry Collection *Varnit Ras*

Abstract

The poet places his trust in the young. He addresses them and calls them to action, as in "We, the Youth": "In the name of caste and religion / and religious sect / someone plots a conspiracy; / entering our country, / someone plants / the tree of terrorism." This connects with his poem "The Flag of Victory": "Let the enemies / of the motherland burn; / keep the fire kindled." It is precisely this enemy against whom the flag of victory must be raised: "Keep the fire kindled; / keep the flag of victory flying." And again in "We, the Youth" he says: "Someone plants / the tree of terrorism; / we Indians are lions— / someone comes into the lion's den / to wake the lion."

Keywords: Umesh · Paswan · poetry · collection · Varnit Ras · criticism · Maithili

The poet trusts young people, and therefore both addresses them and calls them to action. In "We, the Youth" he writes: "In the name of caste and religion / and religious sect / someone plots a conspiracy; / entering our country, / someone plants / the tree of terrorism."

A related thought occurs in his poem "The Flag of Victory": "Let the enemies / of the motherland burn; / keep the fire kindled."

It is against this very enemy that the flag of victory is to be unfurled: "Keep the fire kindled; / keep the flag of victory flying." In "We, the Youth" he likewise says: "Someone plants / the tree of terrorism; / we Indians are lions — / someone comes into the lion's den / to wake the lion." For the youth of the country are: "I am the bullet; / I am the gunpowder; / I myself am dagger and sword." Who, then, is the pistol for this bullet, or the fire for the gunpowder? The answer is the young people themselves, who are both dagger and sword.

Does his poetry, then, possess an energy based simply on enmity? No, not at all: "If you extend a hand in friendship, / then I myself am the garland of flowers, / the necklace around your neck." The poet does not care for the game of pulling one another down, and he says:

Outwardly, such an innocent little child; / inwardly, he calls us fools. / For years I have watched / the neglect of Dalits in every form.

The destruction caused by flooding compels the poet to speak: "How shall I go to the ridge of the field this time / and speak of / a clod as heavy as a seer, / shoots thick as sugarcane, / stalks like a pounding pestle?" At Gabahā Sankrānti he must ask: "How shall we get by / growing only kās and paṭer grasses?" Addressing the Kosi, he says: "You have divided Mithila into two: / to the east, Saharsa and Supaul; / to the west, Madhubani and Darbhanga; / in the middle, nothing but sand and dust."

Yet there is also mention of the construction of the Nirmali bridge: "Tell me, how much longer should we remain silent? / This time we have built the bridge."

Umesh Paswan is as concerned as Ambedkar was about the conduct of educated Dalits towards ordinary Dalits: "I myself am a Dalit; / I know the pain of Dalits; / I am astonished at the behaviour of certain individuals. / Though himself a Dalit, / that person has forgotten his own community; / abandoning his own language and dress, / he has adopted another's habits and manner."

He asks society: "I am a Dalit; / I spend my life in hard labour, / yet I still burn."

The poet has been influenced by Jagdish Prasad Mandal, and expresses this through a poem: "I am a servant of Mithila, / a disciple of Jagdish Babu. / He did not feed me laddus; / he gave me no lump of sugar candy."

But he has by no means abandoned humour:

We shall tug one another's hair, / O dancing girl, / this very time, with you!

Spring's arrival draws his attention not only to flowers and leaves but also to the many other elements of living existence: "New buds and clusters of blossom appear on trees; / the whole expanse of fields grows fragrant with the flowers of wheat, khesari, flax, lentils and mustard; / a bee colony has built its hive on the sinduri mango tree, frightening the mischievous onlooker; / the sunbird chirps after drinking from the hibiscus flower; / the crow and the cuckoo have fallen into a quarrel."

He cannot understand the practice of refusing water touched by another person: "How may body touch body, / yet water touched by me be considered untouchable? / What offence am I being punished for? / Why do you regard me as dishonourable?"

People have divided even the friendship of Sudama and Krishna: "People separated the two friends, / like a wall across their paths, / though they once laughed and played together ..."

Why has this condition arisen? "We endured everything, / though we were descendants of Salhesh, / for as long as we remained silent."

He adds: "How much longer shall I write of Dalit suffering? / The message from Salhesh's village."

But does the language and culture of Mithila belong to someone else? No: it belongs to us, and the poet takes pride in it:

Behind the plough a heron walks; / the ploughman loudly urges his oxen onward, calling them 'Babu' and 'Bhaiya'.

He is indignant about the nation's development and its politicians: "The leaders here are rolling in wealth; / but look at the roads and streets—"

"They are like a plate filled with thick mud."

And this is how he describes the great national highways (the NH roads): "At the haunted bend, the national highway has become a crossroads of death."

Even a buried corpse worries about the direction in which people are moving: "The buried dead body is writhing; / from within, it raises its fingers—"

"Its own fingers."

His pen ranges freely over women's devotion to work: "Over there the womenfolk pull up the seedlings; / some exchange jibes about mothers-in-law and sisters-in-law; / others sing sohar and samdaun songs."

The poet also says much through rhyme. Consider his account of labour migration to Punjab:

"If the old ox is still there in the month of Āṣāḍh, / there is pain in the ribs, / and the man of the house is in Punjab, / then understand: the household has come to grief."

He issues an appeal: "How much injustice does the poverty of literature inflict on me? / Let someone speak! / Let someone raise a voice on my behalf."

And one must demand one's rights: "I will no longer listen / to that old song of sixteenfold completeness—"

The rains break the embankment and turn the village into an expanse of the Kosi and Kamala rivers: "The surface was still low; / bullfrogs, insects and ants—"

"Were raising a din; / the sun had barely risen when the little creatures began to chirp."

How, then, shall we speak of all the kinds of rasa expressed in *Varnit Ras*? Does the poet's spring contain only leaves and flowers, giving fragrance and delight to the eye? Would that satisfy an empty, burning stomach? The rasa of the spring described by this poet therefore cannot be the beauty of fruitless flowers—and it is not. This is Dalit discourse by a Dalit poet, one who bears the legacy of Salhesh and has not forgotten his culture, speech, sohar songs or samdaun laments. That poet is Umesh Paswan. His view of

spring and of the crossroads on the national highway is different; so his poetry is different too.

Gajendra Thakur

Supplementary Discussion

A related thought occurs in his poem "The Flag of Victory": "Let the enemies / of the motherland burn; / keep the fire kindled."

It is against this very enemy that the flag of victory is to be unfurled: "Keep the fire kindled; / keep the flag of victory flying." In "We, the Youth" he likewise says: "Someone plants / the tree of terrorism; / we Indians are lions — / someone comes into the lion's den / to wake the lion." For the youth of the country are: "I am the bullet; / I am the gunpowder; / I myself am dagger and sword." Who, then, is the pistol for this bullet, or the fire for the gunpowder? The answer is the young people themselves, who are both dagger and sword.

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The rains break the embankment and turn the village into an expanse of the Kosi and Kamala rivers: “The surface was still low; / bullfrogs, insects and ants—”

43. Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*

Abstract

Epic or lyrical narrative (gīta-prabandha): Prescriptions about the number of cantos in an epic, the nature of its hero, his birth into a noble family, and similar requirements have now become little more than intellectual exercises. Just as prose narrative is divided, according to length, into short-short story, short story and novel, so a novel rendered in verse—with dramatic passages appearing from time to time—may be called an epic.

Keywords: Ramlochan · Sharan · Ramcharitmanas · literary criticism · Maithili

Epic or lyrical narrative (*gīta-prabandha*): Prescriptions concerning the number of cantos of an epic, the nature of its hero, his high birth, and the like have become little more than intellectual exercises. Just as prose narrative is classified by extent into short-short story, short story and novel, so the versification of a novel, with occasional dramatic passages, may be termed an epic. If we go back to the Rigvedic tradition, the epic ought more properly to be called a lyrical narrative, or *gīta-prabandha*.

Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's lyrical narrative, the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*: Readers of Maithili have generally encountered the story of Rama, or the *Ramayana*, in two works: Chanda Jha's *Mithila Bhasha Ramayana* and Laldas's *Rameshwar Charit Mithila Ramayana*. Whether in the school and university Maithili curriculum, general books of criticism or scattered articles in journals, the very existence of this third *Ramayana* has scarcely been acknowledged. We should also understand that the public accepts judgments made on the basis of literary criticism only when those judgments represent truth. Even today, the uninterrupted ceremonial recitation of the *Ramayana* in Mithila usually draws upon Valmiki's *Ramayana* or Tulsidas's *Ramcharitmanas*. For a long time I wondered why. I distributed copies of Chandra Jha's *Ramayana* and Laldas's *Mithila Ramayana* among groups conducting these uninterrupted recitations, but everyone said much the same thing: both were priceless treasures of Maithili literature, yet the musical cadence of Tulsi's *Manas* suited continuous recitation, even though it belonged to another language. Shankardev employed Maithili rather than his own Assamese precisely because Maithili was musical. I could not accept that a language with such musical qualities had failed to produce a melodious *Ramayana* fit for uninterrupted public recitation. The evidence to the contrary is *Shri Ramcharitmanas*, Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili verse rendering, which

preserves the original meanings as fully as possible and follows corresponding metres. Why have our critics failed to recognise this pearl? Why has it not even been mentioned beside the two more familiar Maithili *Ramayanas*? No book by the late Harimohan Jha was published by the Maithili Academy during his lifetime; he received the Sahitya Akademi Award only after his death. Acharya Ramlochan Sharan is the author of Maithili's largest epic and, to my mind, its most complete *Ramayana*. When I gave a photocopy of the epic to an organisation in eastern Mithila that organises uninterrupted *Ramayana* recitations, its members were astonished and decided to recite this work the following year. This must be seen as a failure of Maithili literary criticism; the epic itself cannot be dismissed as a failure. I had heard of the Acharya's *Manoharpothi* since childhood, but never of this work. Why does the discussion of Maithili's largest epic end with *Sitayan*? That Shri Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili *Shri Ramcharitmanas* is the largest epic is a fact; it does not depend on the favour of literary critics or historians of Maithili. In the section "A Brief Account of the Background" (*Kiñcit Pūrvavṛttam*) of his book, the Acharya writes in Sanskrit: "The eminent Maithili writer Shri Harimohan Jha, on hearing of this undertaking, was greatly delighted and encouraged me repeatedly" (*Mithilābhāṣāyāḥ mūrdhanyā lekhakāḥ Śrīharimohanajhāmahodaya niśamyaitad vṛttaṃ paramāhlādaṃ gatā bhūyo bhūyaś ca mām utsāhitavantaḥ*). He goes on to write: "I am sincerely grateful to Professor Shri Surendra Jha 'Suman' and to Pandit Shri Shivshankar Jha of the editorial department" (*Prādhyāpakasya Śrī Surendrajhā 'Suman' tathā sampādanavibhāgastha Paṇḍita Śrī Śivaśaṅkarajhā-mahodayasya hṛdayenāhaṃ kṛtajño'smi*). All of them had seen and appreciated the undertaking.

The singability of Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*: Consider the opening of the Acharya's *Sundarkand* and compare its musical quality with the *Ramayanas* of Chanda Jha and Laldas:

> Jambavan's words were pleasing; / Hanuman heard them with great delight in his heart. [1] / Until then, my friends, let us wait here in pain, / living on roots and forest fruits. [2]
>
> Until I have gone and seen Sita, / the task cannot be fulfilled and our hearts gladdened. [3] / Saying this, he bowed his head to all, / and departed in joy, holding Raghunath in his heart. [4]

> On the ocean shore stood a beautiful hill; / with a playful leap he mounted it. [5] / Again and again he held the heroic Rama in his heart; / the son of the Wind assumed immense strength. [6] / The mountain that Hanuman pressed with his feet / sank straight down towards the netherworld. [7] / Like Raghupati's unerring arrow, / Hanuman sped swiftly forward. [8] / The ocean, recognising the messenger of Raghupati, / said to Mainaka: "His labour is great." [9]

Tulsidas lived in Akbar's time, and there is now some difference between his language and ours, but his verses remain just as singable. The Acharya preserved Tulsidas's musical quality while removing linguistic difficulty. The Sanskrit verses at the beginning of each *kand* are taken from Tulsi's *Manas*. Although this Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* is an adaptation of Tulsi's *Manas*, it deserves to be counted as an original Maithili epic, just as Kamban's Tamil *Ramayana* and Tulsi's *Manas* are counted in their respective languages. While adapting Valmiki's *Ramayana* into Tamil, Kamban compared the original to an ocean of milk and himself to a cat planning to drink all that milk at once. It is also true that neither Kamban nor the Acharya claimed to have created an entirely original *Ramayana*: both described their works as adaptations of their precursors. Yet Kamban made Rama divine in his poem, whereas Valmiki presented him as an exemplary human being. Valmiki narrates Sugriva's marriage to Vali's wife after Vali's death, while Kamban depicts Vali's wife as remaining a widow throughout her life. The Acharya did not have to make changes of this kind, because Tulsi's *Manas* was already on the people's lips; he needed above all to sustain its musical cadence.

Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's lyrical narrative, the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*, and its expressions of prejudice against women, Shudras and forest communities: Let us consider a controversial verse from the *Manas* and see how meanings can be distorted. At the end of the Acharya's *Sundarkand*, when the ocean refuses Rama a route to Lanka, Rama says: "Lakshman, bring my bow and arrows. / I shall dry up the ocean with the fire of my shafts." [1]

> The ocean then speaks with folded hands: "Drum, rustic, Shudra, animal and woman— / all are fit to be chastised."

One interpretation offered of the line is that all those named—drum, rustic, Shudra, animal and woman—are fit to be instructed or corrected: the argument runs that the rustic, Shudra and woman supposedly lack education, the animal lacks human understanding, and an untaught player produces noise rather than music from a drum. But at that moment the ocean is becoming an antagonist; its utterance cannot automatically be taken as the poet's or author's opinion. A literary work contains virtuous and wicked characters alike, and both kinds of speech may come from their mouths. An author's success depends on whether the author can

distinguish himself from the characters. Yet Tulsidas—and therefore, in several places, Acharya Ramlochan Sharan—fails to maintain this distinction. Such unnecessary remarks about Shudras and non-dvija communities are especially troubling in the context of feudal society. Mithila's *smṛti* writers continued the tradition later. It is more surprising still to find Maithil authors making such gratuitous remarks in Sanskrit works produced under British rule, when the colonial authorities described Brahmins and non-Brahmins alike as "black Indians."

The Acharya removed the difficulty of Tulsi's language rather than his period-bound orthodoxies or harsh attitudes. Caste prejudice is visible in other verses besides the controversial one just cited.

Consider the third verse following doha 12 of the Ayodhyakand in the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*:

> A foolish woman of ill-disposed understanding and lowly birth plots—
> By what contrivance may a wrong be accomplished tonight? [3]

Consider the first verse after doha 59 of the Ayodhyakand:

> The daughters of Kols and Kiratas are suited to the forest;
> Fate has created them deprived of the enjoyment of happiness. [1]

Consider the fourth verse after doha 161 of the Ayodhyakand:

> Even the Creator cannot fathom a woman's heart;
> It is a mine of deceit, sin and every fault. [4] (Even the Creator cannot comprehend the workings of a woman's heart: it is laden with deceit, wrongdoing and faults!)

Consider the third verse after doha 193 of the Ayodhyakand:

> Those whom both worldly custom and sacred teaching account lowly
> Feel sanctified, as though touched by a shadow, when the water is sprinkled. [3]

Tulsidas—and after him Acharya Ramlochan Sharan—often fails to separate his own outlook from the attitudes of his characters. (In adapting Valmiki, Kamban frequently distances himself from inherited assumptions in accordance with a newer age.) Thus, after doha 250 of the Ayodhyakand, the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* puts the following words into the mouth of a forest-community character:

> We consider this our greatest service:
> That we do not steal vessels or clothing. [3]

Consider the seventh verse following doha 62 of the Balkand:

> Although the world contains many cruel sorrows,
> None is harder to bear than humiliation on grounds of caste. [7]

But when, in a twentieth-century Sahitya Akademi publication, a Maithili essay on Lorik claims that Lorik rose against Shudra oppression of Brahmins, how can one blame Akbar-era Tulsidas or Acharya Ramlochan Sharan, his metrical translator, alone? Just as Vishnu Sharma, while narrating the tales of the *Panchatantra*, sometimes becomes gratuitously harsh towards women and Shudras, so too does the *Ramcharitmanas*.

Distinctive features of Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's lyrical narrative, the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*: The work is divided into Balkand, Ayodhyakand, Aranyakand, Kishkindhakand, Sundarkand, Lankakand and Uttarkand. There are certain changes in the carefully organised narrative of Valmiki's *Ramayana*. The style and portrayal of characters are elevated. *Śṛṅgāra rasa*, the sentiment of love, does not predominate, but appears in the relationship between Rama and Sita both in union and in separation. The principal, governing rasa is peace or tranquillity, though the whole is absorbed into devotion to Rama. Devotion predominates without diminishing the importance of knowledge and action. Though the divine with attributes (*saguṇa*) is privileged, the importance of attributeless devotion (*nirguṇa bhakti*) is not lessened. Rama is Brahman, in both its formless and manifest aspects; the individual self and Brahman are one. The poem is suffused with ideals: keeping one's word, devotion to one's father and brothers, a woman's love and fidelity to her husband. All kinds of figures of speech occur, chiefly metaphor and simile. Although the narrative employs the *kaṛvak* form based on dohas and chaupais associated with romance narratives, it also uses Sanskrit metres. The Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* employs the song forms of Vidyapati; the *chhappay* metre of heroic poetry; doha and soratha; the *kavitt* and *savaiyā* of the bards; gnomic aphorisms; and such metres as *ghanākṣarī*, *tomar* and *tribhaṅgī*. Various human folk beliefs and ritual practices are described throughout. Its purposes are liberation, the public good and the establishment of Rama's rule. Besides Rama, it praises Krishna, Shiva (whom Rama worships during the building of the bridge) and Ganesha. The depiction of nature and character alike is distinctive. The poet tells a story, but at intervals he also presents it through the conversations of Bharadvaja and Yajnavalkya, and Garuda and Kakabhushundi. The dialogic technique is used extensively: whether in the exchanges between Lakshman and Parashuram, Manthara and Kaikeyi, or Ravana and Angada, one encounters lively verses comparable to dramatic dialogue. Balkand at the beginning and Uttarkand at the end form two poles of the narrative. Uttarkand depicts the deteriorating guru–disciple relationship and Brahmins selling the Vedas and falling into corruption, but it also outlines the ideal of Ramrajya.

The place of the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* among Maithili lyrical narratives: No account of Rama's life, in Maithili or another language, can

escape the influence of Valmiki's *Ramayana*. Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili rendering of Tulsi's *Manas* in corresponding metres is particularly significant because it never neglects distinctively Maithili elements. In scale—and, I would argue, in quality as well—it remains the largest Maithili lyrical narrative, or epic, produced so far.

Supplementary Discussion

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The singability of Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*: Consider the beginning of the Acharya's *Sundarkand* and compare its musical quality with the *Ramayanas* of Chanda Jha and Laldas:

On the ocean shore stood a beautiful hill; / with a playful leap he mounted it. [5] / Again and again he held the heroic Rama in his heart; / the son of the Wind assumed immense strength. [6] / The mountain that Hanuman pressed with his feet / sank straight down towards the netherworld. [7] / Like Raghupati's unerring arrow, / Hanuman sped swiftly forward. [8] / The ocean, recognising the messenger of Raghupati, / said to Mainaka: "His labour is great." [9]

Tulsidas lived in Akbar's time, and there is now some difference between his language and ours, but his verses remain just as singable. The Acharya preserved Tulsidas's musical quality while removing linguistic difficulty. The Sanskrit verses at the beginning of each *kand* are taken from Tulsi's *Manas*. Although this Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* is an adaptation of Tulsi's *Manas*, it deserves to be counted as an original Maithili epic, just as Kamban's Tamil *Ramayana* and Tulsi's *Manas* are counted in their respective languages. While adapting Valmiki's *Ramayana* into Tamil, Kamban compared the original to an ocean of milk and himself to a cat planning to drink all that milk at once. It is also true that neither Kamban nor the Acharya claimed to have created an entirely original *Ramayana*: both described their works as adaptations of their precursors. Yet Kamban made Rama divine in his poem, whereas Valmiki presented him as an exemplary human being. Valmiki narrates Sugriva's marriage to Vali's wife after Vali's death, while Kamban depicts Vali's wife as remaining a widow throughout her life. The Acharya did not have to make changes of this kind, because Tulsi's *Manas* was already on the people's lips; he needed above all to sustain its musical cadence.

The ocean then speaks with folded hands: "Drum, rustic, Shudra, animal and woman— /all are fit to be chastised."

One interpretation offered of the line is that all those named—drum, rustic, Shudra, animal and woman—are fit to be instructed or corrected: the argument runs that the rustic, Shudra and woman supposedly lack education, the animal lacks human understanding, and an untaught player produces noise rather than music from a drum. But at that moment the ocean is becoming an antagonist; its utterance cannot automatically be taken as the poet's or author's opinion. A literary work contains virtuous and wicked characters alike, and both kinds of speech may come from their mouths. An author's success depends on whether the author can distinguish himself from the characters. Yet Tulsidas—and therefore, in several places, Acharya Ramlochan Sharan—fails to maintain this distinction. Such unnecessary remarks about Shudras and non-dvija communities are especially troubling in the context of feudal society. Mithila's *smṛti* writers continued the tradition later. It is more surprising still to find Maithil authors making such gratuitous remarks in Sanskrit works produced under British rule, when the colonial authorities described Brahmins and non-Brahmins alike as "black Indians."

Consider the third verse following doha 12 of the Ayodhyakand in the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*:

Consider the first verse after doha 59 of the Ayodhyakand:

Consider the fourth verse after doha 161 of the Ayodhyakand:

Consider the third verse after doha 193 of the Ayodhyakand:

Tulsidas—and after him Acharya Ramlochan Sharan—often fails to separate his own outlook from the attitudes of his characters. (In adapting Valmiki, Kamban frequently distances himself from inherited assumptions in accordance with a newer age.) Thus, after doha 250 of the Ayodhyakand, the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* puts the following words into the mouth of a forest-community character:

We consider this our greatest service:

Consider the seventh verse following doha 62 of the Balkand:

But when, in a twentieth-century Sahitya Akademi publication, a Maithili essay on Lorik claims that Lorik rose against Shudra oppression of Brahmins, how can one blame Akbar-era Tulsidas or Acharya Ramlochan Sharan, his metrical translator, alone? Just as Vishnu Sharma, while narrating the tales of the *Panchatantra*, sometimes becomes gratuitously harsh towards women and Shudras, so too does the *Ramcharitmanas*.

Distinctive features of Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's lyrical narrative, the Maithili *Ramcharitmanas*: The work is divided into Balkand, Ayodhyakand, Aranyakand, Kishkindhakand, Sundarkand, Lankakand and Uttarkand. There are certain changes in the carefully organised narrative of Valmiki's *Ramayana*. The style and portrayal of characters are elevated. *Śṛṅgāra rasa*, the sentiment of love, does not predominate, but appears in the relationship between Rama and Sita both in union and in separation. The principal, governing rasa is peace or tranquillity, though the whole is absorbed into devotion to Rama. Devotion predominates without diminishing the importance of knowledge and action. Though the divine with attributes (*saguṇa*) is privileged, the importance of attributeless devotion (*nirguṇa bhakti*) is not lessened. Rama is Brahman, in both its formless and manifest aspects; the individual self and Brahman are one. The poem is suffused with ideals: keeping one's word, devotion to one's father and brothers, a woman's love and fidelity to her husband. All kinds of figures of speech occur, chiefly metaphor and simile. Although the narrative employs the *kaṛvak* form based on dohas and chaupais associated with romance narratives, it also uses Sanskrit metres. The Maithili *Ramcharitmanas* employs the song forms of Vidyapati; the *chhappay* metre of heroic poetry; doha and soratha; the *kavitt* and *savaiyā* of the bards; gnomic aphorisms; and such metres as *ghanākṣarī*, *tomar* and *tribhaṅgī*. Various human folk beliefs and ritual practices are described throughout. Its purposes are liberation, the public good and the establishment of Rama's rule. Besides Rama, it praises Krishna, Shiva (whom Rama worships during the building of the bridge) and Ganesha. The depiction of nature and character alike is distinctive. The poet tells a story, but at intervals he also presents it through the conversations of Bharadvaja and Yajnavalkya, and Garuda and Kakabhushundi. The dialogic technique is used extensively: whether in the exchanges between Lakshman and Parashuram, Manthara and Kaikeyi, or Ravana and Angada, one encounters lively verses comparable to dramatic dialogue. Balkand at the beginning and Uttarkand at the end form two poles of the narrative. Uttarkand depicts the deteriorating guru–disciple relationship and Brahmins selling the Vedas and falling into corruption, but it also outlines the ideal of Ramrajya.

44. A Multidimensional Critical Study of the Poetry of Booch Ji

Abstract

In Booch Ji's poem "Jethi Kareh," the poet says that the Kareh rises at daybreak and swells even when the rainfall is slight. Its danger mark is very high; why, then,

is it agitated? At the end the poet suggests that it will break its embankment and bring devastation. This is a straightforward reading of the poem.

Keywords: Booch Ji · poetry · multidimensional criticism · critical theory · Maithili

Jethi Kareh (The Elder Kareh)

In "Jethi Kareh," Booch Ji says that the river rises at dawn and overflows even after light rain. Its danger level is very high; why, then, does it become so restless? Finally he anticipates that the Kareh will breach its embankment and cause devastation. That is the poem's ordinary reading. From a structuralist perspective, its rising in the morning implies the expectation that it does not rise at other times. That it overflows despite scant rainfall is presented as something that ought not happen. Sunlight glitters on the water, eddies form near the bends, and the river engulfs the heart of the raised homestead. As the sandy deposits grow, the poet's patience breaks. Turning from structuralism to history, we discover a new significance for a new age: the danger level that seemed so high in the poet's day is no longer so high because of the silt and sediment that have accumulated between the embankments. The younger generation therefore encounters a poem whose meaning has separated itself from its author. Now let us turn from structuralism to deconstruction. A deconstructionist would say that structuralism's fixed poles have acquired a philosophical rigidity. The river's swelling after light rainfall, the folly of engineers trying to imprison the Kareh behind embankments, and the poet's prediction that it will breach them and bring disaster all raise the question of whether the poet's own polarity is permanent or transient. Return once more to historical context. In magical-realist fiction, when we enter the past we encounter the obsession with embankment construction in the 1960s: embankments would be made taller and broader, would confine the river, and would supposedly confer innumerable benefits on humanity. A character inhabiting that magical-realist past would read this poem differently for a third time. The author's presence would disappear and the play of language would begin. A character who lives in a magical-realist future would find yet another meaning; the earlier high danger mark would be almost unintelligible, and the character would search anew for the poem's feeling. Yet deconstruction itself becomes caught in its own net. Much will have changed, and much will remain. Rain will persist; so will the river, in transformed form. Its water will continue to glitter in the sunlight, and rising and overflowing will endure.

Song of Welcome

The ordinary reading of "Song of Welcome": the poet welcomes the guests, but what song of celebration is possible amid the grievous cry of

Mithila's uprooted earth? The bees are thirsty, the fruit trees are withered; what can a ceremonial gathering accomplish under such conditions? Along with poetry, one will have to carry a staff; along with aesthetic relish, a rough cudgel. A note beneath the poem identifies its occasion: a welcome to guests attending the Vidyapati Memorial Festival in 1984 at Baidyanathpur village, Rosera block, Samastipur district. That period marked the beginnings of large-scale outmigration from Mithila. The bridge across the Ganga at Hajipur had been built, yet the development model appeared to have failed. Faith in vast embankments was collapsing. Devastating floods harmed agriculture and farmers; industries based on local crops were absent, and there was no visible campaign for education. In that situation, the task of welcoming a ceremonial assembly fell to the poet. **Dhvani theory:** In the *Dhvanyaloka*, Anandavardhana holds that literature communicates or produces meaning indirectly. His theory explains the structure and operation of suggested meaning, rasa as aesthetic experience, and figurative ornament. For Anandavardhana, suggestion (*dhvani*) is the soul of poetry. The suggested meaning arrives indirectly but in an organised form; hence meaning and symbol emerge as two related principles and give rise to rasa. Nyaya and Mimamsa resisted this theory, arguing that dhvani has no separate existence, being the outcome of inference already subsumed under secondary signification, and that not everything can be encompassed in words. **Reading "Song of Welcome" through dhvani:** By saying that Vidyapati, Shiva incarnate and conqueror of death, has died, the poet brings both meaning and symbol immediately before us. Nyaya rejected the theory of dhvani, but Booch Ji, the poet of Kariyan—the village of Udayana—is a poet rather than a philosopher. He produces a powerful pattern of suggestion: our misfortune has taken root and become indestructible; what will a mere ceremonial assembly achieve? The poet then urges the audience to recite poetry but keep a staff on the shoulder, the source of rasa in one hand and a stout stick in the other. Moving coherently through these symbols, the poem nevertheless welcomes its guests. **A Marxist reading:** The poet's work is conceived as extending beyond the recitation of verse. Acceptance is set beside resistance, old beside new, development beside death. If "Song of Welcome" had divorced itself from its circumstances to indulge in hollow exclamations, Marxist criticism would rate it poorly—as it might many other songs of ceremonial welcome and praise in Maithili. Instead, the poet makes it part of a dynamic process, turning it into one of Maithili's finest welcome songs.

A Daughter Becomes a Mountain

The ordinary reading of "A Daughter Becomes a Mountain": the cherished daughter has become a heavy water pot around her father's neck. She arrived as though on a flying vehicle, but Hari abandons Garuda and asks

for a car. Thirty-five grams of gold have been secured, yet the expense of the wedding night is still demanded, and the bridegroom's party will bring ten vehicles. Electric bulbs are lit everywhere, but darkness persists at the centre. Dasharatha asked for no money; Rama said nothing. History even knew Krishna's love marriage, but what difference does that make? Janaka is crying out in the present. A father has gripped his son's throat, households have become slaughterhouses, and villages have become marketplaces. **A sociological reading:** The poem protests against the dowry system. In the society of that time—and still today—the cherished daughter who once seemed to arrive upon a flying chariot becomes an intolerable burden to her father because of dowry demands.

Song of Sorrow

The ordinary reading of "Song of Sorrow": hearing the cuckoo's plaintive song, one beholds a flowering grove through tear-filled eyes; a readily won victory of the ocean of peace upon the golden summit of valour. Just as an embrace begins, innumerable crooked thorns pierce the body. Beauty came for two moments and departed; the honey of love turned bitter. Night's lament dissolves into dawn. **A formalist reading:** Notice the tear-filled eyes viewing the blossoming grove; the fierce form of a blazing cremation ground appearing upon the bed of love; and the easy victory of the ocean of peace upon the golden peak of courage. The poet makes skilful use of language's unfamiliar possibilities. It is this that gives his writing its poetic quality. The concentration of opposites, their unexpected combinations, and a diction rich in verbal figures make this poem distinctive. The entry of thorns into flowers and similar constructions render "Song of Sorrow" particularly successful from a formalist viewpoint.

I Keep Remembering the Village

The ordinary reading of "I Keep Remembering the Village": bread was scarce and even *bathua* greens lacked salt, yet in Calcutta the speaker cannot stop remembering home. If one irrigates with the Kareh's water and grows pearls, will the children be ruined? Is it better to remain a respectable gentleman beside the Hooghly or a labourer along the Kamala? The woods along the Kamala are better than Eden Gardens. A husband offers his wife a garland in Eden Gardens, while a woman of Tirhut searches for *dhatūra* and *ākon* flowers for her Bhola in the Kamala woods. **A feminist reading:** This is a poem of migration. The Tirhut woman seeks flowers for her Bhola while Bhola is away. **An existentialist reading:** Bhola himself bears responsibility for his condition, his solitary existence, and his anxiety.

Son Dai

The ordinary reading of "Son Dai": her life will hold neither laughter nor pleasure—but why? Groups of children depart, young people depart, and eventually the elders wither away. Why, then, does Son Dai keep her faith? The answer emerges later: forgetting her homeland, she endures life in exile. As her age advances, how long will she have a home to dwell in? **A feminist reading:** Theories made by men in a male-centred society, even if they are theories of poetry, are not necessarily appropriate for women. For whose sake has Son Dai forgotten her land and endured migration?

Famine

The ordinary reading of "Famine": the poet describes tying the yoke of hunger to a plough and beating time upon it. The failure of rainfall brings famine, famine brings soaring prices, and the sky above burning villages turns red. A dance of death begins in India like that in Lanka, but this time even Vibhishana's house will not be spared, for the garland of severed heads is tied strand by strand. A mother clutches the earth in full armfuls. Ten-headed Ravana rolls his twenty eyes and shakes his head. **The principle of appropriateness (*aucitya*): In the* Aucityavicāracarcā*, Kṣemendra considers appropriateness central to literature. It ought to be present in the word, sentence, meaning of the composition, quality, figure of speech, rasa, grammatical case, verb, gender, number, adjective, prefix, particle, time, place, lineage, vow, fundamental principle, inner character, intention, disposition, selection of essentials, imagination, circumstance, thought, name and benediction. This universe trembles: it is trembling itself. After the reading of poetry comes peace—peace everywhere, and peace spreading through the mind. Reading "Famine" through aucitya: This is not merely famine; it is* Mahākāla*, the Great Time of destruction. The image of a hungry yoke tied to the plough and the beating of time upon its frame is appropriate to Mithila's particular place and historical moment. Ravana will be uprooted, and Vibhishana too will not survive.

Your Lips

The ordinary reading of "Your Lips": lips stained by betel and the beloved's lips; the beloved applies the lime of speech and colours her cheeks red as *kattha*. But where is the reed pipe of love? Dawn's redness resembles her lips, and evening without her is restless. If a butcher becomes the beloved's husband, I shall become a fragmented Rahu. Nectar is scarce even in heaven: how much harder, then, to find her lips! The Sakri mill will become great if I learn science from Vishvakarma, and sweetness will emerge from that mill. Her lips resemble the ripe segments of a sugarcane stalk. Even in rebirth I shall come near you, beloved, as rice and prepared food. Yet after all this, the intended meaning remains unexpressed

through words. **A reading through the theory of figures of speech (*alaṃkāra*): Bhamaha understands ornament as a form of suggestive compression that gives pleasure. Dandin and Udbhata developed theories of literary figures further. Figures are fundamentally verbal and semantic; they may also be classified by resemblance and contrast, logical reasoning, popular conventions, poetic conventions and the apprehension of hidden sense. Mammata organises sixty-one figures into seven groups: simile, metaphor, indirect praise, illuminating connection, contrast, opposition and combination. "Applying the lime of speech" is indirect praise; the red cheeks like* kattha*, betel-coloured lips, dawn red as the beloved's lips, and her lips like mature sugarcane joints are similes. "But where is the reed pipe, the longing of love?" operates through similarity and opposition. The line about wandering restlessly without her employs metaphor. Indian reflections on poetry: Consider the idea of art as a path towards liberation, and the posture of Nataraja, in which creation and destruction share a rhythm. A permanent emotional disposition, intensified and brought to fulfilment, becomes rasa. Sita and Rama experienced many such rasas, as the* Valmiki Ramayana *shows. Krishna teaches the Indian philosophy of action and is also a connoisseur of rasa. A theory was needed to understand the relish of art, and Bharata composed the* Natyashastra*. Abhinavagupta wrote a commentary on Anandavardhana's* Dhvanyaloka*; Bhamaha in the sixth century, Dandin in the seventh, and Rudrata in the ninth advanced discussion of poetic ornament. Reading "Your Lips" through rasa theory: Bharata holds that rasa arises through dramatic performance. Drama exists to represent rasa and to produce it. Its emergence depends upon determinants (*vibhāva*), consequent expressions (*anubhāva*) and accompanying transitory feelings (*vyabhicāribhāva*). The stable emotion ripens into rasa, which an audience can savour. Bhatta Lollata argues that determinants and consequences intensify the permanent emotion to create rasa; actors participate through investigation and imagination. He assigns little importance to the poet or to the audience. Shaṅkuka holds that spectators must enter imaginatively into the performance, much as one treats a painting of a horse as a horse. Bhatta Nayaka locates the effect of rasa in the spectator, regards poetic language as distinctive, and describes the listener's or viewer's soul as joining the supreme soul through aesthetic experience. The pleasure of rasa is delight in one's own being and makes self-realisation possible. Rasa theory is therefore oriented towards the hearer, viewer and reader. In the context of structuralism and poststructuralism, Roland Barthes invokes the death of the author to emancipate readers from authorial intention: the author separates from the work and the reader seeks meaning independently. "You laid the stone-white lime of speech / And adorned the cheeks with the red blood of* kattha*": these are determinants that make the heart surge with feeling, an expressive consequence. The theory of* sphoṭa*: Bhartrhari's* Vākyapadīya

holds that the meaning of a word or sentence is communicated by sphoṭa*, the integral manifestation of linguistic sense. One distinguishes letter-, word- and sentence-level* sphoṭa*. No cognition is possible without a relation to language; this became an element of Indian epistemology. Meaning can be communicated without assuming that individual letters, words and complete sentences all exist simultaneously.* Sphoṭa *is* śabdabrahman*, language as the fundamental creative principle. Letters, words and sentences do not coexist at every moment. A spoken sound in isolation does not bear a complete word's meaning; sounds emerge and perish as the word unfolds. In* sphoṭa*, meaning is conveyed although individual letters, words or sentences need not be simultaneously present at the precise moment of apprehension. A letter contributes to meaning through its sequence within the word, and words do likewise within a completed sentence. Sankhya, Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa and Vedanta do not accept this theory; they maintain that letters and their sounds are adequate to produce meaning. Jacques Derrida's account of deconstruction and dissemination bears an interesting proximity to the idea of* sphoṭa*. Reading "Your Lips" through* sphoṭa*: Although the poet lives in Kariyan, associated with Udayana and the Nyaya tradition that rejects* sphoṭa**,* Nyaya's objections do not prevent his poem from working through that principle. The unspoken thoughts of the heart find expression when he compares the beloved's lips to an unattainable thief of hearts.

Booch Ji, the poet of Kariyan, the village of Udayana, says that sounds dissolve, one after another, and words have failed to disclose the intended meaning. His communicative achievement in "Your Lips" and elsewhere in the collection comes not simply from isolated words but from *sphoṭa*. Through the world's most rhythmic and melodious language, Maithili—in Yehudi Menuhin's phrase—Booch Ji emerges as the most lyrical poet after Vidyapati, and compels us to define Maithili poetry anew.

45. Videha: Logo, Vidyapati, Ugna, Mithila and Maithili

Abstract

The *Mahabharata* mentions that Indra's standard was dark blue. Rama's standard was red or saffron, bearing an image of the Sun, his family's tutelary deity. Arjuna's flag, according to the epic, bore an image of the monkey king.

Keywords: Videha · logo · Vidyapati · Ugna · Mithila · critical theory · Maithili

I.

The *Mahabharata* mentions that Indra's standard was dark blue. Rama's standard was red or saffron and bore the image of the Sun, his tutelary deity. Arjuna's flag carried the monkey king. Nakula's bore the fabulous *śarabha*. According to the *Atharvaveda*, this creature has two heads, two beautiful wings, a long tail, and eight sharply clawed toes, like a lion's. Abhimanyu's standard bore the *sāraṅga* bird; Duryodhana's was a serpent standard. Drona's displayed a deerskin and a water pot, while Karna's displayed a chain used on an elephant's leg and also the Sun.

Vishnu's standard bears Garuda; Shiva's bears Nandi the bull.

At a Durga pavilion, weapons and musical instruments—*ṭakkā*, *paṭaha*, *mṛdaṅga*, bronze cymbals, but not the flute—along with standards, armour and bows, are worshipped. The sword should be worshipped first, followed by the knife, dagger, bow, spear and armour; then the fly-whisk, umbrella, flag, pennant, kettledrum, conch, throne and horse. In my view, no flag of Mithila can be complete without incorporating all these elements.

I.

Like Indra's Shachi, like Gauri to the Lord of Gauri, like sweet-natured Rati to Kama and Sita to Rama, like Shri to Vishnu, she who is the beloved of King Padmasimha, famed throughout the world for her policy and conduct, the daughter of an eminent Brahmin, shines upon the earth. [9]

The verse quoted above is the ninth introductory stanza of Vidyapati's *Śaivasarvasvasāra*. Its meaning is that Queen Vishwasadevi, a Brahmin-born woman of outstanding virtues and sweet temperament, renowned for her political acumen, adorns the world. She was as dear to King Padmasimha as Shachi to Indra, Gauri to Shiva, Rati to Kama, Sita to Rama and Lakshmi to Vishnu. [9] II.

South of the Madhubani district headquarters, near Pandaul railway station, lies the village of Bhawanipur. Nearby, about six feet below the ground, is a Shiva linga known as Ugranath Mahadeva. A popular belief holds that, at the beginning of the fifteenth century, Vidyapati's companion Ugna drew Ganga water from his matted hair and offered it to the great poet when he was nearly overcome by thirst. This raised the poet's suspicion, and he asked the companion's true identity. Shiva then revealed his real form at that place.

Such an account can be credited only when faith is joined to reason and science. Of Shankaracharya it is said that he enclosed a river in his water pot. What actually happened, the account suggests, was that a ridge separated a flooded region from a drought-stricken region. With his

disciples' help, Shankara opened the intervening passage and emerged holding his *kamaṇḍalu*, the ascetic's water pot. People saw water flowing to the other side, praised him for bringing the river into his pot, and thanked him for saving one area from drought and the other from flood. Opportunists subsequently turned the practical feat into a miracle. I hope that, when writing about Ugna, you will likewise weigh the story with both reason and faith.

On 20 March, the fourteen-day circumambulation of Mithila—nowadays chiefly associated with Janakpur—enters Janakpur by way of Kua Rampur. Two principal processional groups lead it, those of Mithila Bihariji and Kishoriji, accompanied by numerous other temple and devotional groups. Some pilgrims travel with their animals. The circuit begins at Kachuri Math in Dhanusha. Its first overnight halt is at Hanuman Nagar on the new-moon night and its fifteenth at Janakpur on the fourteenth lunar day, as the source states. On 21 March, the Phagun Parikrama day, the pilgrimage includes an inner circuit of Janakpur Municipality, approximately eight kilometres. Holi is celebrated in and around Janakpur on 22 March.

The fifteen stops of the middle Janakpur pilgrimage circuit and their principal deities or features are: (1) Hanuman Nagar—Hanuman; (2) Kalyaneshwar—Shiva linga; (3) Girija Sthan—Shakti; (4) Matihani—Vishnu temple; (5) Jaleshwar—Shiva linga; (6) Manai—Sage Mandava; (7) Dhruva Kund—Dhruva temple; (8) Kanchan Van—no temple, only beautiful scenery; (9) Parvat—five mountains; (10) Dhanusha—fragments of Shiva's bow; (11) Satokhadi—seven ponds associated with the Seven Sages; (12) Harushaha—Vimala Ganga; (13) Karuna—no temple, only beautiful scenery; (14) Bisaul—Vishvamitra temple; and (15) Janakpur, where the circuit concludes. Pilgrims stay at the Barahbigha grounds and in pilgrims' shelters.

The short circuit is eight kilometres; the middle circuit forty *kos*, or 128 kilometres; and the extended circuit 268 kilometres.

1. Ugratara Sthan: the family goddess (*gosāunī*) of Mandana Mishra, Mahishamardini Bhagavati at Mahishmati. In the fourteenth century Queen Padmavati, the senior queen of King Shivsinha, built a temple here. The temple was maintained under the Khandwala dynasty, and the king would visit during the autumn Navaratri celebrations for worship and residence.

Devotees of Tara come here in great numbers during Durga Puja.

2. Kapileshwar Sthan: five kilometres west of Madhubani, with the Madhav temple and an ancient Shiva linga. Kapila, the founder of Sankhya philosophy, is said to have established a temple here. The present shrine

was built some 250 years ago by Maharaja Raghav Singh of Darbhanga. In ancient times the sea extended towards the Himalayas and land subsequently emerged. After Kapila burned the 60,000 sons—or soldiers—of Sagara near the Ganga Sagar pilgrimage site on the Bay of Bengal, he came to Kapileshwar. Even Ganga Sagar now lies somewhat away from the sea.

Janaki Navami: the ninth day of the bright half of Vaishakh, associated with the human Sita. Ram Navami: the ninth day of the bright half of Chaitra. Vidyapati's death anniversary: the thirteenth day of the bright half of Kartik, associated with *desil bayna*.

Vivah Panchami: the fifth day of the bright half of Agahan. Shatananda served as priest at the marriage of Rama and Sita. Mithila painting on the wedding pavilion, welcoming rites, *gosāun* songs and the *Naina Jogin* customs continue today as they did, according to tradition, at the marriage of the divine couple.

In antiquity Mithila was the land of the Maithils, known as Videha, whose capital was Mithila, founded by Mithi according to the *Bhavishya Purana*. Its other names include Videha, Mithila, Tirabhukti, Tirhut, Tapobhumi, Sambhavi, Suvarnakanana and Mantili. The *Mithila Mahatmya* in the *Brihad Vishnu Purana* describes an extended annual circumambulation of all Mithila, 268 kilometres in the account given here: from the Kaushiki to Singheshwar Sthan, then Simaria Ghat, the Himalayan foothills, back to the Kaushiki and finally Singheshwar Sthan. The middle circuit is forty *kos*, 128 kilometres, once performed in five days but nowadays in fifteen. It begins on the first day of the bright half of Phagun, described here as the new-moon day, and finishes on the full moon. The Phagun pilgrimage is the best known, though circuits can also be undertaken in Kartik and Vaishakh.

Panini: Mithila is the city where enemies are crushed. *Janaka* is derived from *jana* (*viś*). Nimi founded Vaijayanti (Janakpur), and Mithi founded the city of Mithila.

The *śarabha* appeared on Nakula's flag: a fabulous animal with two heads, two wings, a long tail and eight lion-like claws. When Vishnu assumed his Narasimha incarnation, Shiva is said to have taken the form of a *śarabha* to pacify him. The five colours of Mithila painting signify earth, water, fire, sky and air. An *aṅkuśa* is a double-curved goad used to control an elephant; Ganesha's goad is associated here with controlling the mouse.

Unicode: a 1,200-year-old figurine and 500-year-old manuscripts. The following are the counts of conjunct forms absent from, or substantially different in, Bengali: *ka* group (10), *kha* (4), *ga* (8), *gha* (4), *ṅa* (4), *ca* (6), *ja* (5), *jha* (4), *ṭa* (3), *ṭha* (2), *ḍa* (2), *ḍha* (3), *ṇa* (6), *ta* (6), *tha* (3), *da* (8), *dha*

(3), *na* (6), *pa* (8), *pha* (2), *ba* (4), *bha* (3), and *ma* (11). For final conjuncts: *ya* (2), *ra* (2), *la* (4), *va* (4), *śa* (9), *ṣa* (8), *sa* (8), and *ha* (8). Three-consonant conjuncts number 49 and four-consonant conjuncts one. Also listed are one *bikārī* form, two short/long *gvaṅg* forms, and five additional kinds of *añjī*, including the one described by Anshuman Pandey.

Vidyapati's flight to Nepal with Lakhima, in the context of Sanskrit and Avahattha; after his return his final work was *Durga Bhakti Tarangini*. Before Vidyapati, Jyotirishwar; Vidyapati wrote *jhumar*, *nachari*, *Maheshvani*, *jog-uchiti*, *batgavani*, *parichhani*, *kobar*, *parati*, *barahmasa*, *man*, *Tirhut*, *drishtikut*, and songs on Shiva, Bhagavati and the Ganga, Vishnu, Shakti, and Hara-Gauri.

46. *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt*: An Integrated Bilingual, Multidimensional Literary Review

Abstract

A parallel Maithili–Bajjika examination of Dr Rameshwar Prasad's work. Book reviewed: *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt*, Kishore Prakashan, Muzaffarpur, first edition, 2000. Since its inception, *Videha* has upheld literary justice for voices ignored, marginalised or excluded by established institutional criticism.

Keywords: Bajjika · song · music · integrated · bilingual · multidimensional · literary criticism

A Parallel Maithili–Bajjika Examination of Dr Rameshwar Prasad's Work

Book reviewed: *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* · Kishore Prakashan, Muzaffarpur · First edition, 2000

Part One: A Four-Dimensional Critical Examination

1. Editorial Introduction

From its beginning, *Videha* has advocated a literary justice that places at the centre voices left outside, pushed to the margins and unheard within established institutional traditions of criticism. This is the fundamental pledge of the parallel-literature movement: to accord authentic critical dignity to the voices of the people, women, Dalits, working people and neglected communities scarcely named in literary histories of institutions such as the Sahitya Akademi.

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From this standpoint, reviewing a Bajjika song collection in a Maithili journal is no alien undertaking; it is a natural expression of fellowship with a sister vernacular. Maithili itself has struggled for a long time to assert its distinct literary identity within the Hindi-speaking belt. That struggle gives us particular sympathy when we try to understand the literary aspirations of Bajjika, an unscheduled language subordinated in two directions.

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The present study examines the work through four dimensions: (a) Indian poetics—rasa, dhvani and vakrokti; (b) Western critical theories—Marxism, structuralism and formalism, postcolonial and subaltern criticism, dialogism, orality and performance, and feminist perspectives; (c) Navya-Nyāya epistemology; and (d) the Videha framework of parallel history. Bringing these perspectives together makes a multilayered reading of a folk-song collection possible.

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2. Introduction to the Work

Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt is a collection of songs by Dr Rameshwar Prasad, first published by Kishore Prakashan, Muzaffarpur, in 2000. The author was principal of B.P.C. College at Lalganj in Vaishali district and wrote fluently in both Bajjika and standard Hindi. Among his varied works are *Kuntī ke Beṭā*, a Bajjika narrative poem; *Bajjika Lokgīt*; *Ham Kahā̃ Hatī*, Bajjika literary essays; and the Hindi poetry books *Ai Lāsh! Suno* and *Kahī̃*

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The book is dedicated to his eldest son, Gopal Ji Kishore. Its preface, an introductory essay, is by Acharya Shambhunath Mishra of the Rashtriya Sanskrit Sansthan, who detects in the author's poetry a brilliance comparable with Dinkar's. The collection contains 105 songs divided into nine thematic groups. These compositions are meant not merely to be read but to be sung: the author's declared intention is that Bajjika-speaking performers should be able to set them to melodies and *rāgas*.

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3. The “Author's Statement” and the Question of the Bajjika Language

The book's “Author's Statement” is not simply a modest personal declaration; it is a linguistic and cultural manifesto. The author says that he began organising gatherings of Bajjika poets at Lalganj in 1971, sang folk songs at street-corner meetings and published a selection in 1976 under the title *Doctor Saheb ke Bajjika Lokgīt*. He nevertheless felt that performers lacked enough newly composed songs to sing. The present collection was born from his resolve to address that absence.

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In this essay the author argues strongly for Bajjika's independent linguistic identity. He observes that its verbal forms differ across the region: *bā* east of the Gandak, *chhī* around Darbhanga and Samastipur, *hatī* near Muzaffarpur and Hajipur, and *hath* towards Sheohar. Yet such variation does not in itself destroy the language's unity.

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Here he cites the proverb, "Every four *kos* the water changes; every eight *kos* the speech." He goes further, arguing that Bajjika is an ancient language descended from Pali and that Maithili and Bhojpuri were influenced by Bajjika rather than the other way round.

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From a critical standpoint this linguistic claim seems driven more by commitment than established evidence. Modern linguistics generally regards Maithili, Magahi, Bhojpuri and Bajjika as related members of the eastern, or Bihari, Indo-Aryan group; it is not simple to establish any one as the mother of all the others. The underlying impulse, however—to give a neglected vernacular its own literary identity and body of songs—is entirely genuine. The author himself accepts that literary work must rise above caste partisanship and sectarian mentalities and become a form of service to literature; this generous outlook is the healthiest element of his preface. Also quoted there is a 1977 letter by Jagdish Chandra Mathur, a founder of the Vaishali Festival, advising that new songs be written for the people, including fisherfolk, and urging writers to "turn towards the earth." The letter clarifies the popular inspiration behind these compositions.

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4. Structure and Survey of the Collection's Contents · 4. Organisation and Survey of the Contents

The songs are arranged in nine groups: (a) Krishna (1–20); (b) love and erotic sentiment (21–42); (c) the heroine's suffering (43–52); (d) nature (53–60); (e) human nature (61–78); (f) the condition of the country (79–84); (g) poverty (85–95); (h) agriculture (96–103); and (i) spring (104–105). This sequence traces a natural emotional journey, beginning with devotion and love, passing through nature, arriving at sociopolitical reality, and finally resting in the musical sweetness of agricultural labour and springtime. The author's claim is that songs on all three planes—classical song, light music and folk song—are represented.

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(a) Songs of Krishna

The twenty songs in the Krishna section are an outgrowth of the Vidyapati–Surdas tradition, recast in unmistakably rustic Bajjika idiom. Krishna is a playful deceiver, while Radha's mind is full of separation, wounded pride and reproach. The refrain of the first song, “How shall I walk along the pathway now? People cast their eyes upon me,” suggests the lover's dilemma amid public propriety. The second, “Kanha casts a glance —oh, Kanha is a trickster,” renders Krishna's playful deception in village imagery. The section is strongest when dramatic elements enter, particularly the dialogue songs between sister-in-law and brother's wife, where an episode at the water-drawing place becomes a lively exchange of questions and answers. The mention of Kubja gives expression to Radha's jealousy and sense of injustice. Songs such as “Little Kanhaiya Plays” also contain a gentle touch of parental affection.

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(b) Love and the Erotic Sentiment

The love section (21–42) frequently evokes early dawn, drowsy eyes and the courtyard at daybreak. A line such as "The eyes grew languid; the bangles smiled" vividly depicts the heroine's preparations and gestures in the morning. Although this love poetry is sensuous, it remains within customary village decorum. Its life is the tension between longing and restraint.

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(c) The Heroine's Suffering

Here the collection's most original and affecting voice emerges, as traditional poetry of separation becomes a living social document. The husband who has gone away is no imaginary figure: he embodies the harsh realities of Bihar's labour migration, travelling to "Calcutta" in search of a livelihood. "I went looking for my beloved, all the way to Calcutta" gives that suffering a popular voice. In another song—"No one knows where my husband, gone abroad, may be"—the migrant husband becomes intoxicated by his earnings, drinks alcohol and neglects his household. The heroine's grief then exceeds private longing and becomes an awareness of familial and social disintegration.

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husband, gone abroad, may be"—the migrant husband becomes intoxicated by his earnings, drinks alcohol and neglects his household. The heroine's grief then exceeds private longing and becomes an awareness of familial and social disintegration.

(d) Nature

The nature section (53–60) is suffused with rural images of the cuckoo, *papiha*, *mahua*, spring and moonlight. In the line "O dark cuckoo, with such dark-dark eyes, Ram, they do not seem dark," the play on *sām*—dusky and Shyam, a name of Krishna—joins nature and devotion. Sound figures such as *kuhukī-kuhukī*, *ṭah-ṭah* and *lah-lah* convey the audible beauty of the natural world.

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(e–g) Human Nature, the Condition of the Country, and Poverty · (e–g) Human Nature, National Conditions, and Poverty

In these three sections the poet is most incisive and committed. His satire has a sharp edge and unmistakable targets: the chair of power, corruption, politicians and bribery. "The chair has made the world dance" attacks the corruption of authority, while "I am the most righteous man of all, yet people call me corrupt" bitterly mocks the corrupt person's self-deception. Mythological references sharpen the satire: "Watch your step, Tulsi—the times have turned topsy-turvy" applies the stories of Rama, Bharata, Ravana and Dasharatha to modern political absurdity. The poverty section (85–95) addresses inflation, debt, daughters' dowries and the desperation of the poor. "The season of the poor, O Rama, distributes nothing but calamity" articulates their continuing cycle of distress. The tone recalls the progressive popular poetry of Nagarjun.

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(h–i) Agriculture and Spring · (h–i) Farming and Spring

In the agricultural section the poet celebrates the dignity of labour and of farmers: "Come, I shall become a farmer; you become the farmer's wife," and "Work and eat with dignity; give up the fruits of exploitation" convey a wholesome consciousness of labour. Dialogue songs between husband and wife (97–98) capture the tenderness of domestic life. Finally, the spring section, with its Holi songs (104–105), returns the collection to Krishna's play and the sensuous rhythms of spring, producing a graceful circular ending.

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5. First Dimension: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti · 5. First Critical Dimension: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti

5.1 Examination of Rasa

From the perspective of rasa, this collection is a treasury of aesthetic sentiments. In the Krishna section, the permanent emotion is *rati*, love, transformed into the sweetness of devotion; Krishna is the supporting determinant (*ālambana-vibhāva*), while the Yamuna, flute and Vrindavan are excitant determinants (*uddīpana-vibhāva*). The heroine's gestures are consequent expressions (*anubhāva*), and curiosity, anxiety, jealousy over Kubja, and sorrow are transitory feelings (*vyabhicāribhāva*). In the childhood-Krishna songs, the permanent feeling of parental love gives rise to *vātsalya-rasa*.

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In the section on the heroine's suffering, a subtle transition between rasas can be observed. Conventionally, separation is *vipralambha-śṛṅgāra*, love-in-separation, which implies hope of reunion. But where separation results from social and economic compulsion—migration and poverty—the weakening of hope inclines that emotion towards *karuṇa-rasa*, the sentiment of pathos. This transition from separation-love to pathos is one of the collection's defining emotional features.

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The political songs on human nature, national affairs and poverty test the limits of traditional rasa classifications. Their feeling is neither pure comedy nor merely pathos: it is the modern register of anger, outrage and rebellion, which does not fit comfortably within the classical eight- or nine-rasa scheme. The seeds are clear of what progressive criticism sometimes calls the "rasa of indignation" or "rasa of revolt." That is this collection's innovation in rasa. The agricultural songs offer zeal for work —a "heroism of labour," corresponding to heroic action—and rural tranquillity; the spring and Holi songs bring the joy of love-in-union. The range of rasas is thus extensive.

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5.2 Examination of Dhvani

The power of these songs lies more in suggestion (*vyañjanā*) than in literal or secondary meaning (*abhidhā* and *lakṣaṇā*). All three types of *dhvani* occur. **Suggestion of an idea (*vastu*-dhvani): simply naming Kubja implies Krishna's neglect of Radha without saying it outright, and the word "Calcutta" suggests the whole tragedy of migration. Suggestion of figures (*alaṃkāra*-dhvani): the punning *sām*-*sām* combines darkness with Shyam*

*or Krishna, while "fire in the heart" and "the cord of affection" evoke figurative meanings. Suggestion of rasa (*rasa-dhvani*):** throughout the section on the heroine's grief, sorrowful love-in-separation is suggested rather than bluntly stated.

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The refrain or *ṭek* plays a distinctive role in this suggestive process. Repetition accumulates resonance in it; returning after each stanza, it increases the density of suggestion, the vernacular counterpart of Anandavardhana's *rasa-dhvani*. Most of the suggestion here is of the *vivakṣitānyaparavācya* type, grounded in semantic power: the literal sense remains intended while pointing beyond itself.

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5.3 Examination of Vakrokti

According to Kuntaka, *vakrokti*, oblique expression, is the soul of poetry. His six levels of obliqueness apply to this collection as follows. (1) **Phonetic arrangement:** alliteration and sound-painting in forms such as *kuhukī-kuhukī*, *ṭah-ṭah*, *lah-lah* and *jhan-jhan*. (2) **The first part of the word:** native and vernacular forms such as *ḍagariyā*, *najariyā* and *bāsuriyā*, made attractive by the affectionate suffix *-iyā*. (3) **The latter part of the word:** Bajjika verb forms such as *delā*, *jāle*, *kahe nā* and *banī ha* themselves create distinctive turns of expression charged with cultural meaning. (4) **Sentence-level obliqueness:** refrains, questioning formulas such as "How shall I walk now?" and dialogue construction. (5) **Episode-level obliqueness:** the village-waterplace episode and the dialogues between sisters-in-law and between spouses. (6) **Composition-level obliqueness:** the arrangement of nine thematic groups, from devotion through spring, forms the oblique overall design.

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Assessment: the poet's most effective obliqueness occurs in phonetic arrangement and the latter part of words—their sound and distinctly Bajjika morphology. But when he descends into direct didactic statements, especially in some political and poverty songs, obliqueness weakens and literal declaration predominates. There the characteristic indirectness of poetry is less pronounced.

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6. Second Dimension: Western Critical Approaches · 6. Second Dimension: Western Critical Perspectives

6.1 Marxist Reading

Songs about national conditions and poverty are saturated with class consciousness. Migration to "Calcutta" pictures labour extraction from village to city and the "reserve army of labour," transforming Bihar into a reservoir of workers for Bengal's industries. The "chair" songs criticise the state apparatus—politicians, officials and the police—and call to mind Althusser's repressive and ideological state apparatuses. The relationship between base and superstructure is clear: the poet demonstrates how economic conditions—poverty, indebtedness and dowry—produce consequential disasters in the social superstructure. Lines such as "Blood has become cheap" depict the commodification of human life, while criticism of an independence that has benefited only politicians and performers sharply indicts the postcolonial bourgeois state. By composing

songs in the language of ordinary people, the poet assumes the role of a Gramscian “organic intellectual.”

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6.2 Structuralism and Formalism · 6.2 Structuralism and Formalism

The collection is organised around binary oppositions: village/elsewhere, poor/rich, earth-and-hoe/chair-of-power, righteous/corrupt, food/hunger. The “chair” becomes a shifting signifier of authority, while the cuckoo and *papiha* recur as signs of separation. Formally the refrain is the structural backbone. What Cleanth Brooks calls “tension” runs between the sensuous surface of the love songs and the moral and social undercurrent. “I am the most righteous man of all” deploys dramatic irony: the corrupt speaker unknowingly condemns himself.

6.3 Postcolonial and Subaltern Criticism · 6.3 Postcolonial and Subaltern Discourses

Spivak's question, “Can the subaltern speak?”, is pertinent here. The poet borrows the voices of an abandoned wife and a hungry farmer, but their representation is mediated: an educated college principal speaks “for” the subaltern, itself a problem for critical inquiry. Yet the choice of a subordinate language like Bajjika is already a decolonising gesture against the dominance of Hindi and Sanskrit. Migration to “Calcutta” is an afterlife of colonial economic geography.

Spivak's question, “Can the subaltern speak?”, is pertinent here. The poet borrows the voices of an abandoned wife and a hungry farmer, but their representation is mediated: an educated college principal speaks “for” the subaltern, itself a problem for critical inquiry. Yet the choice of a subordinate language like Bajjika is already a decolonising gesture against the dominance of Hindi and Sanskrit. Migration to “Calcutta” is an afterlife of colonial economic geography.

6.4 Theory of Dialogism (Bakhtin)

Songs structured as conversations between a husband's sister and his wife, or between husband and wife, are literally dialogic. A plurality of voices becomes audible: the heroine, the sister-in-law, the farmer, and even the politician who satirises himself. Holi songs exhibit carnivalesque festivity —the brief liberty of a world turned upside down through playful transgression.

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6.5 Orality and Performance Theory · 6.5 Orality and Performance Theory

Seen through Ong, Parry–Lord and Zumthor, these are oral-formulaic compositions. They employ recurring refrains, name-formulas or epithets such as “Chhaliya” and “Giridhari,” and memory-supporting repetitions. Textual mobility or *mouvance* also appears: the alternation between *sohāgin* and *suhāgin* within a single song shows the fluidity of oral practice. These songs are not only “texts”; they are “performances,” in which the primacy of the voice is essential. Simplicity and repetition should therefore be regarded as virtues of the genre rather than defects.

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6.6 Feminist Implications

The heroine's-suffering section presents a gendered subjectivity: the interior world of the abandoned woman who endures the “living widowhood” imposed by a migrant husband. Yet the collection is also divided against itself: in many love songs the woman's beauty is fashioned through the male gaze. Recognising this contradiction is central to a feminist reading.

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divided against itself: in many love songs the woman's beauty is fashioned through the male gaze. Recognising this contradiction is central to a feminist reading.

7. Third Dimension: Navya-Nyāya Epistemology · 7. Third Dimension: Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

This dimension illuminates the songs' structure of knowledge through the conceptual instruments of post-Gangesha Nyaya. At the outset it must be clear that this is an epistemological reading, not a claim that the folk poet consciously employed Navya-Nyaya. Rather, the logical and relational structures implicit in our understanding of the poems become especially clear when viewed from this philosophical standpoint.

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7.1 Verbal Cognition, Acquisition of Word-Meaning, and Vernacular Signs · 7.1 Verbal Cognition, Learning Meaning, and Local Signs

According to the Naiyayikas, verbal cognition (*śābdabodha*) arises through four conditions: expectancy (*ākāṅkṣā*), semantic fitness (*yogyatā*), proximity (*āsatti* or *sannidhi*) and intention (*tātparya*). Prior knowledge of the relation between word and referent (*śaktigraha*) is also required. The principal means of acquiring this relation is usage: children learn conventional signs from the speech and conduct of elders. From this perspective, vernacular words in folk songs—*ḍagariyā*, *bālam*, *sāiyā*—derive their understood meanings from the practices of the performing community. Song itself becomes a communal act through which meaning is acquired. In elliptical folk-song sentences, expectancy is often satisfied through context and intention; shared cultural knowledge supplies the unstated words.

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through context and intention; shared cultural knowledge supplies the unstated words.

7.2 Determining Objecthood: The Relational Structure of Knowledge of Separation · 7.2 Determination of Objecthood: The Relational Structure of Separation

In post-Gangesha Nyaya every cognition is defined through its relation of "objecthood" (*viṣayatā*) to its object. This has three forms: substantiveness (*viśeṣyatā*), qualifierhood (*prakāratā*) and relationality (*saṃsargatā*). Consider the heroine's cognition, "My husband has gone away" (*mama patiḥ proṣitaḥ*). Here substantiveness pertains to the husband, qualifierhood to being absent or separated, and relationality to the connection between the substantive and its qualifying condition. The complete cognition is constituted by this threefold determination of its object. The key to the poetic effect is that when the reader's or listener's subsequent cognition apprehends the heroine's separation under a particular qualification conducive to pathos, rasa arises. Thus the theory of *viṣayatā* offers a relational explanation of the transmission of rasa.

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7.3 Cognition of Absence: Relational Absence, Counterpositiveness, and Delimitation · 7.3 The Knowledge of Absence: Relation and Delimitation

The central cognition of separation, "The husband is not here" (*patiḥ atra nāsti*), is a cognition of absence, analysable through the Navya-Nyaya apparatus of delimiters (*avacchedaka*). It is a relational absence (*saṃsargābhāva*), not mutual non-identity (*anyonyābhāva*): the husband is absent from the courtyard by the relation of contact or conjunction. The counterpositive is the husband, the delimiting property of counterpositiveness is husbandhood, and the delimiting relation is conjunction or proximity; the locus of the absence is the courtyard or house. The poetic subtlety is that absence is not usually easy to apprehend as an object of experience. The poet, however, makes this relational

absence almost perceptible through excitant determinants—the empty courtyard, the silent bed. Such objectification of absence is a source of the section's poetic force.

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7.4 Simile and Metaphor: Obstruction of Primary Meaning, the Basis of Secondary Signification, and Figurative Usage · 7.4 Simile and Metaphor: Primary Meaning and Secondary Signification

At a metaphorical expression the Naiyayika analysis proceeds as follows. In "the fire of the heart," the primary meaning—actual fire inside the heart—cannot be coherently connected with its context. This obstruction of literal meaning supplies the basis for secondary signification (*lakṣaṇā*). Similarity in the capacity to cause suffering then becomes the ground of figurative usage (*gauṇī-vṛtti*), whereby a painful mental condition is indicated. In "the cord of affection," the relevant similarity is the ability to bind. For a simile, knowledge of resemblance is itself the product of comparison as a means of knowledge (*upamāna*): cognition of an entity qualified by resemblance. Navya-Naiyayikas locate these processes within primary or secondary signification and resist the literary theorists' proposal of a separate faculty of suggestion (*vyañjanā-vṛtti*).

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primary or secondary signification and resist the literary theorists' proposal of a separate faculty of suggestion (*vyañjanā-vṛtti*).

7.5 Invariable Concomitance, Conditions and Deviant Reasoning in Songs of Maxims · 7.5 Vyāpti, Upādhi and Fallacious Generalisation in Aphoristic Songs

The logic of aphoristic songs becomes clearer through the theory of invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*). In Gangesha's formulation, vyapti is the non-occurrence of a reason in any locus where the probandum is absent (*sādhyābhāvavad-avṛttitva*). The line "Whoever commits oppression enjoys every happiness" offers a seemingly universal rule: being an oppressor implies being happy. But it contradicts experience and contains a fallacy of irregular concomitance (*savyabhicāra*): the existence of unhappy oppressors shows the reason occurring without the alleged consequence; a condition relating to *dharma* might also qualify the generalisation. The poet's skill lies in knowingly stating a defective universal as though it were certain. When listeners recognise its exceptions, the satire of moral outrage flashes forth. An ethically disordered reality is thus expressed through an ironically false appearance of universal law.

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7.6 Dhvani versus Inference: An Analysis of the Kubja Episode · 7.6 Dhvani and Inference in the Kubja Episode

Literary theorists treat suggestion as an autonomous semantic operation. Naiyayikas, and advocates of inference such as Mahimabhatta, reduce it to inference. The Kubja episode can be reconstructed in inferential form: **subject:** Krishna; **probandum:** neglect of Radha, or attachment elsewhere; **reason:** reports of Krishna's attentions to Kubja, together with Radha's reproaches; **universal concomitance:** wherever a man favours another heroine, he neglects his own beloved. Reflection upon the inferential sign thus produces the suggested meaning as an inference, without needing a

separate semantic faculty. Anandavardhana's response deserves attention, however: poetic wonder arises immediately and aesthetically, whereas inference unfolds through stages of reasoning. The reduction of suggestion to inference thus loses something essential to experience. Both positions should be kept in view.

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7.7 Memory, Latent Impressions and Stimuli: The Memory Processes of Songs of Separation · 7.7 Memory and the Evocation of Separation

Songs of separation are fundamentally awakeners of memory. In Nyaya, experience produces latent dispositions (*saṃskāra*), from which memory emerges with the aid of an activating stimulus (*udbodhaka*). Natural stimuli—the cuckoo's call, the moon, the month of Phagun—act as such activators, awakening impressions formed through earlier experience of the absent beloved. The resulting recollection intensifies the pain of separation. Thus the function of the excitant determinant (*uddīpana-vibhāva*) in poetry parallels Nyaya's causal account of memory as the conjunction of disposition and activating stimulus.

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7.8 Theories of Validity: Externally Established Validity of Folk Song · 7.8 The External Validity of Folk-Song Knowledge

For the Naiyayikas, the validity of cognition is established externally (*parataḥ*)—through correspondence with experience or successful action—rather than being intrinsic, as the Mimamsakas argue. A folk song is a form of reliable popular testimony, a trusted utterance; its account of social suffering is validated externally by the corresponding experience of its community. In this sense, the shared recognition of singers and listeners establishes the reliability of the evidence: collective verification of suffering.

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It bears repeating that all the Nyaya analyses above illuminate the songs' epistemic structure; they are not a history of the poet's conscious intellectual commitments. A folk poet may be accomplished in rasa rather than formal logic. Nevertheless, the clarity with which these philosophical categories reveal the internal relational organisation of the songs' meaning is itself testimony to the deep knowledge embodied in the vernacular voice.

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8. Fourth Dimension: The Framework of Parallel History · 8. Fourth Dimension: A Parallel-History Perspective

From the perspective of Videha's parallel history, this work is counter-canonical. Bajjika, an unscheduled language subordinated between Hindi as an official language and Maithili as a scheduled language, seeks to write itself into literature from outside the institutional literary-Akademi canon. It is a literary history written from the margins.

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Restoring voices: The heroine's-suffering section records the abandoned woman's experience, the divided position between natal and marital homes in *gauna* songs, and the "living widowhood" imposed by a migrant husband—though the author's mediation must be remembered. **Workers' and farmers' voices:** the farming and poverty sections offer a history from below of the erased labourer, the migrant and the indebted cultivator. The political songs voice popular criticism of the postcolonial state, a parallel history opposed to official nationalist narratives, including a critique of an independence that deceived the poor.

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The affinity between Bajjika's and Maithili's counter-canonical struggles is unmistakable. Horizontal solidarity among subordinate languages is the moral centre of this reading. **Evidentiary value:** as parallel history, the songs archive popular memory and preserve the emotional and economic organisation of rural Bihar in the latter half of the twentieth century. Digitisation by Bharatavani (CIIL) is itself a parallel archival act. **Democratic form:** these songs were written for oral performance; literature here is a shared commons, not the private property of elites. Their origin in street-corner gatherings confirms this.

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A self-critical note consistent with parallel principles: the author's linguistic claim—that Bajjika descends from Pali and is the mother of Maithili and Bhojpuri—reproduces, within a counter-canon, the

hierarchical logic of canon-making that the parallel movement resists. Establishing Bajjika's dignity through claims of greater antiquity or priority is less desirable than affirming its equal yet distinctive subordinate identity. Parallel history privileges horizontal fellowship among languages over contests for precedence.

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9. Integrated Assessment: Craft, Achievements and Limitations · 9. Integrated Evaluation: Form, Accomplishment and Limits

In terms of craft, the backbone of the collection is the refrain. The close weave of Bajjika verb forms establishes its linguistic identity; village images —the clay pot, bamboo flute, cuckoo, moon, rice and aluminium plate— along with sound figures create its popular aesthetic texture. Yet there is a tension: Sanskritised phrases such as “the resounding, graceful, new golden anklets” do not always merge with the native idiom, weakening the consistency of some songs.

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Achievement: its foremost achievement is a singable treasury of songs on varied subjects and in many rasas, exactly what the author intended. The social consciousness through which romantic separation becomes a reality of migration, together with explicit political satire, gives the work enduring value. Its deep involvement in ordinary life and the authenticity of its village imagery make it a genuine document of the people.

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Limitation: the collection is uneven. Some political and poverty songs become more propagandistic and didactic than poetic, with literal statements displacing obliqueness and suggestion. Many Krishna and love songs tread ground already familiar from Vidyapati and Surdas. Recurrent images and the imperfect fit between Sanskritised and vernacular diction sometimes jar. The introduction's linguistic claims arise more from conviction than demonstration, and the mediation of subordinate voices raises a representational problem. Nonetheless, simplicity, recurring refrains and lucid emotion are necessary for singability. These songs were made for the stage and the singing voice, not merely for silent reading.

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10. Conclusion

Taken together, the four dimensions show *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* to be a multilayered work: under rasa, dhvani and vakrokti it is a repository of popular aesthetic feeling; from Western perspectives it is class-conscious, dialogic and performance-centred; through Navya-Nyaya it reveals an emotional organisation structured by knowledge of absence, inference and invariable concomitance; and in parallel history it is a counter-canonical document carrying subordinated voices.

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Its lasting value is twofold. On the one hand it is folk-literary evidence of poverty and migration in Bihar; on the other it is an important primary text for comparative study of a vernacular closely related to Maithili and for the questions raised by the parallel-literature movement. Dr Rameshwar Prasad's collection belongs to a tradition in which song is the natural, accessible means by which poets establish a linguistic identity in

ordinary people's minds. The work is an authentic component of the alternative literature whose canon the Videha parallel movement hopes to build; for this reason it commands critical respect.

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Critical method: the study draws upon four dimensions—Indian poetics (rasa, dhvani and vakrokti), Western critical theory, Navya-Nyaya epistemology and Videha's parallel-history framework. All quotations have been taken unchanged from the original book and restricted to the needs of analysis.

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Part Two: Close Reading, Song Structures, and Sociocultural Interpretation

Critical Method · Method of Criticism

The critical method operates on three levels. First comes close reading: detailed attention to words, images, repetition, rhythm, refrains, dialogues and subject matter. Second comes Indian poetics, encompassing rasa, dhvani, figures of speech and oblique expression. Third is sociocultural interpretation, which considers Bajjika's linguistic identity, the representation of women, rural life, poverty, migration, farming, politics and popular memory. These levels are treated together rather than as mutually exclusive methods.

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1. The Nature of the Book: A Meeting of Song, Poetry and Folk Melody · 1. Form and Organisation of the Book

How shall I walk along the pathway now? People will cast the evil eye upon me.

The fundamental strength of *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* is its singability. It is not an ordinary collection of poems but of songs in which line formation, sound, refrain, repetition and musical movement are organised for performance. Its rhythm has a distinctly communal character. The title correctly joins song and music: the text creates a space for the singing voice. Unlike poetry intended only for the printed page, these pieces anticipate the listener's ear and the performer's breath.

Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt is not simply a set of songs. It is an extensive singable world of Bajjika life: love, sorrow and happiness, nature, politics, poverty, farming and the month of Phagun. It links the language of familiar village life with the emotions of everyday existence.

The book begins with Krishna songs, then expands through erotic love, the heroine's suffering, nature, social realities, the condition of the country, poverty and agriculture, ending with spring. This progression gives the volume an emotional architecture: private affection opens into collective social experience and returns at the end to seasonal celebration.

In this sequence the poet begins with Radha and Shyam and the village world of love, passes through the heroine's pain, nature and human character, then addresses the country, the poor and farmers, and finally returns to the colours and rhythms of spring. The movement links personal feeling with public life.

In the opening refrain, common expressions such as *ḍagariyā* (little road or pathway) and “casting the eye” bring poetry directly into everyday life. The road is more than a physical path: it is the public space in which a lover must confront society's watching eyes and judgments.

The book's basic tone can be heard in this opening refrain: direct village speech, a melody made to be sung, the hesitation of love and the gaze of society. *Ḍagariyā* does not signify a road alone but also the passage of love under public scrutiny.

2. The Krishna Section: Folk Devotion and Erotic Love Together · 2. Krishna Songs: The Meeting of Devotion and Love

The first twenty songs centre on Krishna, but this Krishna is not a remote philosophical deity. He is close to village life, to Radha and Shyam's love,

the flute, Yamuna, courtyards, water-drawing places, glances, longing and the swing. Devotion and desire coexist. The songs transpose received mythology into the tone and social experience of Bajjika-speaking communities.

In the Krishna section the deity is not distant or merely philosophical. Among the Yamuna, waterplace, flute, swing, Radha, village beauties, courtyard and village, Krishna is present like one of the people. The songs bring devotion into familiar life.

Separation in the Radha–Shyam episodes is mostly expressed in the rhythm of ordinary speech. Rather than elaborate Sanskritised figures, the poet uses popular images and bodily gestures: eyes, flute, Yamuna, swing, the rains and the behaviour of village lovers. This is a particular strength of the Bajjika rendering of an old literary tradition.

The poet's distinction is that he has given the old Krishna story Bajjika speech, conduct and feeling. Shyam, Radha, the flute, Yamuna, moon and waterplace are familiar traditional symbols, but a local voice animates them afresh.

One achievement of the Krishna songs is this reanimation of mythological figures through local language and cultural practice. Their limitation is the recurrence of conventional images—Radha and Shyam, moon, eyes and flowers—in some pieces. What may look repetitive to a silent reader can nevertheless function effectively as recurring melody and memory in performance.

Images of moon, eyes, flowers, flute and beauty recur frequently. While they sometimes seem repetitive on the page, they acquire force as refrains and aids to memory when sung. Repetition thus has both an artistic limitation and a practical oral function.

3. Love: A Poetry of Body, Gaze and Waiting · 3. Love: Gaze, Body, Modesty and Expectation

The love section has a striking visual character. Eyes, the end of a sari, scarves, moon, lotus, lightning, clouds, fragrance, anklets, hair, lips and flowers recur. The beloved's bodily appearance is rendered through recognisable images of the natural world and the village household. Love is as much a matter of seeing as of feeling.

In this section love appears in vividly visible forms. The sari's end, anklets, eyes, hair, lotus, moonlight, lightning, flowers, air, night and colour become love's language. The poet constructs a sensuous world out of immediate and recognisable images.

In many songs love also takes place in public. The village path, courtyard, roof, riverbank, flower garden and night form its stage. Private emotion must negotiate a social gaze, and the tension between longing and restraint gives these poems much of their force.

Village pathways, courtyards, rooftops, gardens and rivers become stages of love. Private feeling remains in tension with the community's watching eyes. Love is therefore not only an experience of the body but also an experience of social custom and restraint.

The poet's similes are simple and immediately intelligible. Traditional images such as moon, lotus, lightning and the honeyed season are renewed through local verb forms and folk rhythm. He relies less on elaborate figures than on the expressive force of familiar objects.

Descriptions of beauty are sometimes conventional, but Bajjika verbs, modes of address and everyday expressions give them new life. The poet seeks neither difficulty nor rarefied ornament: the image is meant to speak at once to its audience.

4. The Heroine's Suffering: Women's Experience and the Ground of Pathos · 4. The Heroine's Suffering: A Woman's Inner Voice

The section on the heroine's suffering is one of the collection's emotional centres. A husband abroad, waiting, the pressures of marital family, humiliation, loneliness and the insecurity of love become elements of women's inner experience. The songs bring private suffering into contact with social and economic life.

This is among the book's most sensitive sections. The absent husband, the marital home, loneliness, waiting, sorrow, anger and uncertainty in love reveal an inner world experienced from a woman's position. Its social grounding makes the songs particularly affecting.

The migrant husband, life in the marital household, the shadow of child marriage, helpless waiting and failures of communication recur. Yet the women are not invariably passive: in their reproaches, questions and complaints they begin to articulate the terms of their own suffering.

The simplicity of the language deepens the effect of pathos. Short sentences, cries, repetitions and ordinary words keep sorrow from seeming artificial. The heroine's pain is not merely private: it reflects the social conditions of migration and gendered domestic life.

The evocation of *karuṇa-rasa* does not depend upon extravagant lamentation. Simple vernacular sentences, direct addresses and repetitions make it more persuasive. Such simplicity is one of the work's essential achievements.

The achievement here is the special place given to women's emotional life within a recognisable folk-song structure. The limitation is that in other, more overtly erotic songs, women are at times viewed chiefly through their outward beauty. Both tendencies need to be considered together.

5. Nature: Not Decoration but a Living Companion · 5. Nature: Humanity's Living Companion

Night came dressed in kohl-darkness; morning fled like gold.

Rivers, wind, rain, cuckoos, the season of love, henna, flowers, the moon and green fields are not merely background in these songs. Nature participates in human feeling: the river carries separation, the breeze conveys remembrance and the changing season reflects shifts of mood.

The river, wind, rain, cuckoo, henna, Phagun, flowers and moon are no mere decorations. Nature seems to change with the changing human heart. Its motions and feelings are inseparable from those of the people who inhabit it.

In the quoted lines, night becomes animate through *kohl*, and morning shines like *gold*. Such effortless transformation of everyday images into poetic pictures demonstrates the author's gift for visualisation.

The comparison of night with kohl and morning with gold produces a vivid scene despite its simplicity. The poet's most effective imagery often comes from the familiar materials of everyday village life.

Nature's beauty also has a palpable rural geography: fields, river, waterplace, orchard, kadamba tree, cuckoo and Phagun. Consequently the descriptions are not abstract romantic scenery but part of the lived environment.

These images are not abstract. Field, river, waterplace, orchard, kadamba, cuckoo and Phagun all belong to the geography of daily life. The landscape of the songs is the same landscape in which ordinary people work and live.

6. Human Nature: The Expansion of Social Satire · 6. Human Nature: Satire and Social Criticism

The tone changes decisively in the “Human Nature” section. After love and seasonal celebration, the poet turns to officers, ministers, elections, corruption, authority, plunder, moral decline, unemployment and violence. Song becomes an instrument of public accusation.

The book's voice changes in the “Human Nature” section. Officers, ministers, voting, the chair of power, corruption, looting, unemployment,

violence and moral decay come to the fore, displacing the earlier emphasis on love and the seasons.

Several songs are declaratory and sometimes approach direct political statements. Artistically this is risky, because the dominance of an explicit message can diminish poetry's complexity and suggestiveness. Yet these texts remain valuable as testimony to their time and to the social dissatisfaction that shaped them.

Some songs become almost straightforward political declarations. Artistic subtlety sometimes suffers, but as documents of their historical moment such passages remain significant. Their directness makes evident the author's sense of social urgency.

The political vocabulary of minister, officer, election, vote, democracy and chair of power is a modern intrusion into the traditional lexicon of folk song. This mixture firmly situates the collection in its own historical era.

The remarkable point is that the poet does not confine folk song to love and seasonal change; he makes it speak about government, corruption and social discontent.

7. The Country's Condition: National Awareness and Public Concern · 7. The Country's Condition: Civic Concern and National Feeling

In the section on national conditions, the poet's conception of the nation is formed by idealism, opposition to corruption and moral indignation. Independence, democracy, poverty, border crises, education, administration and public responsibility become themes of song.

Songs on the country's condition express concern about freedom, government, education, borders, corruption and civic responsibility. The speaking “I” begins to change from private lover into a member of a larger public.

These songs sometimes approach the form of mass or people's songs. The private “I” gradually becomes a collective “we”; attention shifts from the beloved to civic life. This turn broadens both the scope and the audience of the collection.

Some songs take on the voice of popular mobilisation. Slogans and moral advice can become too prominent, yet the willingness to address national problems directly in a vernacular language is part of the work's courage.

The limitation is that direct instruction or slogans reduce poetic ambiguity in some songs. The achievement is that the author makes civic criticism possible through the language of the people.

Artistic achievement and limitation thus coexist: directness increases popular communication but can also reduce a poem's range of meanings.

8. Poverty: Compassion, Anger and Structural Questions · 8. Poverty: Hunger, Wages and Dignity

For the poor, O Rama, hardship distributes only more misfortune.

The poverty section is among the collection's most socially affecting parts. Inflation, wages, hunger, debt, daughters, land, unemployment, illness and inequality appear as ethical questions rooted in ordinary life. The poor are not presented merely as sufferers but as people with labour, dignity and claims upon society.

Inflation, labour, daughters' futures, loans, fields, hunger, livelihood and inequality define the poverty section. The poor person is more than an object of pity; work, self-respect and struggle are also part of this experience.

The author does not make the poor a passive object of compassion. He represents them through work, dignity and resistance. Some songs call upon God, yet within that appeal one also hears questions addressed to an unjust social order.

At times there is a cry to God, and elsewhere a challenge to the system. Folk faith and social resistance proceed together, making these songs' suffering seem grounded rather than manufactured.

Language is particularly effective here because the poetic vocabulary grows out of life's actual economy: earning, wages, rising prices, fields, borrowing and bread. Such terms connect the songs directly to the material circumstances of their subjects.

Earnings, wages, inflation, fields, debts and bread provide the ground of this poetry. Here language carries an especially palpable social weight.

9. Agriculture: The Aesthetics of Labour · 9. The Beauty of Work in Agriculture

The agricultural section gives lyrical form to the farmer's work, preparing the field, rice, water, green leaves, the uncertainties of cultivation, changing weather and cooperation among village families. At this point the collection's social geography becomes especially concrete.

Farmers and farmers' wives, rice, water, fields, crops, work and weather make up this entire world. Farming is not simply a green and pleasing scene: the poet recognises its hardship and uncertainty as well as its production.

The farmer's life is not represented merely as romantic greenery. Struggle, unpredictable seasons, physical labour and difficulties of production are visible. At the same time, scenes of cultivation bring out the cooperative character of village work.

Here a field is not merely land. It is the basis of family, food, dignity and the future. The joint appearance of farmer and farmer's wife brings rural life before us as collective labour.

These songs convey the book's social geography most concretely. A language that began with the sari's end and the anklet in love poetry now reaches the plough, rice, water and work.

The social landscape is clearest here. The words that began with the sari and anklet of love have moved towards plough, rice, water and labour.

10. Spring: A Return to Rasa, Colour and Festivity · 10. Spring and Holi: A Colourful Return at the Close

Mohan plays at teasing by force, O fair one! How shall I play Holi?

The final two songs return the collection to spring and Holi, to love, play and celebration. It began with Krishna and ends again in the colours of Krishna's Holi. The closing thus gives the sequence a circular shape.

The last songs are about spring and Holi. Since the book began with Krishna and ends once more with his Holi festivities, the whole becomes a kind of completed circle.

After passing through heavy questions of society, poverty, politics and agriculture, the reader returns to colour, Phagun, laughter and bodily joy. This conclusion restores an aesthetic balance.

After politics, poverty, the country's troubles and farming, the reader returns to colour, laughter, love and playful pleasure. The close maintains the collection's emotional balance.

11. Language: Bajjika's Intimacy and its Many Registers · 11. Bajjika's Strength as a Literary Language

The language is the work's most distinctive achievement. The author does not employ Bajjika merely as a decorative touch of “local dialect” but as a full poetic medium. Verbs, pronouns, modes of address, idioms and sound patterns make it recognisably itself.

One of the book's greatest achievements is to use Bajjika as a complete language of literature. Village words, local verb forms, cries, forms of address, sayings and sound give its songs a distinctive character.

Alongside regional Bajjika forms the songs employ Hindi, Sanskritised and modern administrative vocabulary. Love poems draw upon the sari, pathway and intimate terms of address; political songs add elections, ministers, officials, democracy and administration. The language remains open to newer social circumstances.

Modern words such as election, minister, official, democracy and administration appear beside traditional expressions. The language is not confined to an old village world; it has accommodated the experiences and vocabulary of a new age.

The author offers views on the regional varieties of Bajjika and their differing verbs in his introductory statement. From a literary standpoint it is more important that the collection actually demonstrates the language's ability to express many kinds of experience.

The most important literary point is that Bajjika is not merely the subject of the songs: it is their medium. It is used to speak of everything from love to politics and agriculture.

Hindi, Sanskrit-derived expressions and local Bajjika words coexist in the poet's language. This mixture should not be judged solely by a standard of linguistic "purity"; it also bears witness to the multilingual life of twentieth-century northern Bihar.

Hindi, Sanskritised words and Bajjika forms appear together. Rather than measure this only against "purity," we should see it as part of the history of a multilingual region in the twentieth century.

12. Metre, Rhythm, Refrain and Sound · 12. Rhythm, Refrains and Sound

The songs do not all follow a uniform classical metre. Their strength lies in oral rhythm, repetition, roughly balanced lines, rhyme, refrain and vocal movement. Many closing lines return in performance, creating the form's musical backbone.

Their real metre is in speech and melody. Not all follow a single scheme of classical syllabic weight; repetitions such as *rah-rah*, *chal-chal*, *kuhukī-kuhukī* and *āyel-āyel* create rhythm and momentum.

Repetitions such as *rah-rah*, *chal-chal*, *kuhukī-kuhukī* and *āyel-āyel* are striking in the work's sound organisation. Sound conveys not only sense but also bodily movement and energy.

In many songs the final line returns again and again. Sung aloud it becomes a refrain, helps memorisation and intensifies feeling.

In a few places the inequality of metrical quantities is noticeable on the printed page, though the sung melody may well restore the balance. The

collection's rhythmic strength must be assessed with its performance context in view.

Syllabic quantities sometimes look unequal in writing, but the collection relies principally on folk rhythm. Its musical qualities cannot properly be judged by written prosody alone.

13. Images, Symbols and the Folk World

The main symbols of the work—the moon, eyes, flowers, river, Yamuna, clouds, wind, cuckoo, field, courtyard, flute, anklets, the sari's end and Phagun—are familiar objects of ordinary life. Their familiarity allows them to communicate feeling directly.

The principal images—moon, eyes, flowers, river, Yamuna, clouds, wind, cuckoo, field, courtyard, flute, anklets, sari and Phagun—come from everyday popular life. This familiarity gives their meanings immediate accessibility.

The moon signifies bodily beauty; the river, separation and movement; the field, work and livelihood; the courtyard, the domestic world; the pathway, both society's gaze and life's journey; and Phagun, unrestrained festivity. The symbols bind emotional states to local geography.

The moon evokes beauty, the river absence and flow, the field labour and sustenance, the courtyard the household, the path both public scrutiny and the course of life, and Phagun festive freedom. These familiar symbols create the work's shared folk universe.

14. A Feminist Perspective: Achievements and Limitations · 13. Women: Tradition and Their Own Voices

Female characters have a wide presence in the collection: the beloved, wife, heroine, woman waiting for a migrant husband, rural young woman, member of a working family and participant in domestic life. Their many roles bring women's feelings into the songs' emotional centre.

Women appear in many forms: Radha, lover, wife, the woman awaiting a husband abroad, the woman working at home or in the field, the beautifully adorned young woman and the woman in distress. Their presence extends throughout the book.

Critical scrutiny nevertheless shows that some love songs view women from the outside, concentrating on eyes, hair, complexion, gait and bodily appearance. The singer's standpoint may thus be determined by a male gaze, even where the woman's own grief finds expression elsewhere.

In several love songs the woman's exterior appearance dominates. Yet in songs of the heroine's suffering she has her own questions, grief,

complaints and resistance. A feminist interpretation must account for both tendencies.

15. The Work as a Social Document · 14. The Book as a Social Document

Published around 2000, this book is valuable for understanding the social and cultural outlook of rural northern Bihar. Its songs do not concern love and seasons alone: migration, unemployment, inflation, elections, public administration, poverty, farming and gender are also recorded.

Alongside love and nature, *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* writes about the society of its time. Migration, inflation, elections, governance, poverty, fields, wages and unemployment enter the songs as living concerns.

For this reason its value is not merely aesthetic but also cultural and archival. It brings language, popular experience and the social concerns of an era together in one body of song.

The book's importance exceeds the category of "beautiful songs." It is a document of the language, feelings, social concerns and cultural memory of the Bajjika region.

In this sense, the book acts as a bridge between folk tradition and modern popular consciousness.

Thus it connects inherited popular forms with modern forms of public awareness.

16. Artistic Achievements · 15. The Book's Principal Achievements

Establishing Bajjika confidently as a singable literary language.

Creating an extensive world of 105 singable compositions in Bajjika.

Organising 105 songs into nine thematic sections to create a broad emotional world.

Extending the themes from Krishna and love to poverty, politics, farming and spring.

Effective use of folk rhythm, refrains, repetition and natural rhyme.

Effective use of folk melody, refrains, repetition and simple rhyme.

Extending the range of themes from Krishna and love to politics, poverty and agriculture.

Vivid images of village, courtyard, river, field, waterplace, migration and women's experience.

Memorable depictions of village women's experience, migration, fields, weather and community life.

The courage to undertake contemporary social and political criticism in a vernacular language.

The courage to express modern democratic and social criticism through the people's language.

The book's evident confidence in Bajjika as a literary language.

17. Limitations · 16. The Book's Limitations

Excessive repetition of images such as moon, eyes, flowers, beauty and anklets in some songs.

Some love songs repeat images of moon, eyes, flowers and beauty too often.

At points the statement of a political argument overwhelms poetic ambiguity.

Some political songs come closer to speeches than to poetry.

The balance of syllabic quantities is not always uniform under classical metrical rules; the collection principally relies upon folk rhythm.

Syllabic balance is uneven in places, and the songs depend more on popular melody.

Some erotic passages give undue prominence to the outward description of women's beauty.

In a few places the emphasis on feminine beauty remains chiefly external.

The initial claims about linguistic history require independent linguistic evidence for verification.

The claims made at the beginning about the history of the language need separate, independent linguistic verification.

18. Overall Evaluation · 17. Overall Evaluation

The literary importance of *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* lies in establishing Bajjika not merely as the language of collected folklore but as a medium for contemporary creative writing, love, satire, social criticism, pathos and public consciousness. The songs demonstrate its ability to represent a modern social world.

The book's real achievement is to make Bajjika a literary language capable of expressing love, devotion, suffering, laughter, resistance, poverty, farming and national concern alike. Its compass is wider than the preservation of folklore.

The weakest moments occur when argument becomes a direct slogan or instruction, but this weakness is linked to the period's aspiration to create

songs for the people. Taken as a whole, the book is better understood as a broad cultural intervention than as a uniformly accomplished set of lyrics.

At certain points instruction and slogans diminish artistic subtlety. Yet viewed in the context of the entire book, the limitation belongs to its larger social aims. It should not obscure the collection's contribution to Bajjika literature.

Its lasting achievement is not simply to collect popular sensibilities in Bajjika but to establish them as materials for contemporary literary expression.

The book's enduring accomplishment is to place Bajjika's popular feelings into a contemporary literary form rather than merely store them as items of folklore.

Part Three: A Broader Historical, Cultural and Linguistic Context for Bajjika Literature

The Bajjika language and its folk literature, nurtured within an extensive geographical and cultural world, carry what the author regards as an extraordinarily rich and ancient tradition of the Indian subcontinent. Spoken in Muzaffarpur, Vaishali, Sitamarhi, Sheohar and parts of Samastipur in Bihar, as well as in Nepal's Terai, especially the districts of Rautahat and Sarlahi, Bajjika has been classified by some linguists as a "western dialect of Maithili." The source cites the 2001 census as recording approximately 11.5–11.8 million speakers in India and about 238,000 in Nepal. Despite this large population base, the language is described as struggling for survival without adequate institutional support. In this setting, the book *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt*, edited by Dr Rameshwar Prasad and published in Muzaffarpur by Kishore Prakashan in 2000, represents an important undertaking in recording and preserving folk literature.

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The principal purpose of this critical article is to assess Dr Rameshwar Prasad's book against the multiple criteria of literature, sociology, psychology and linguistics. Alongside the literary review, it proposes a multidimensional programme of scientific research into the Bajjika language and its folk literature, intended as a guide for future researchers.

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The Historical Development of Bajjika Literature and Dr Rameshwar Prasad's Contribution · The History of Bajjika Literature and Dr Rameshwar Prasad

The source associates the origins of Bajjika with the ancient Vajji confederacy, centred upon Vaishali and regarded as one of the world's earliest republican polities. It traces the language's evolution through Magadhi Prakrit and Magadhi Apabhramsha, language stages also associated with the emergence of Maithili, Bhojpuri, Magahi, Angika, Bengali, Assamese and Odia. Historically, Prakrit is said to have been used for administration and Sanskrit for religious activity, enriching the vocabulary from both sources. Vidyapati's writings in Avahattha, notably *Kīrtilatā*, are presented as exceptionally close to the structure of contemporary Bajjika, a sign, in the author's view, that the language has preserved its earlier forms.

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The history of Bajjika literature is presented as ancient and distinguished. Among its early authors is Gayadhar, said to have composed in 1045 CE, to have lived in Vaishali and to have travelled to Tibet to propagate Buddhism. A later work is *Sudāmācaritra*, a narrative poem written by Haldar Das in 1565 and treated here as representative of Bajjika. From around the turn of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, Mangniram's

Mangniram ki Sakhi, *Ramsagar Pothi* and *Anmol Ratan*—associated in the account with about 1815—are regarded as important inheritances. A renewal of Bajjika writing is traced from the middle and later twentieth century, when numerous scholars undertook the difficult work of recording literature that had survived in people's memories and voices. The authors and works involved in that renewal warrant careful examination.

A Selection of Bajjika Writers and Works

Writer / editor	Major work or book	Publication year and publisher	Literary genre
Dr Rameshwar Prasad	Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt; Bajjika Lokgīt; Bajjika Swar Saṅgam	2000; Kishore Prakashan, Muzaffarpur	Collection of folk songs
Nirmal Milind	Gitiyā; Tarhāttī Par Taregan; Khissā Pehānī	1984 and 1999; All India Bajjika Literary Conference	Novella, songs and poetry, fiction
Prafulla Kumar Singh ‘Mani’	Bajjika Sahitya ka Itihas	1995; Hansraj Prakashan, Muzaffarpur	Literary history
Dr Awadheshwar Arun	Bajjika Rāmāyaṇa	Not stated	Epic
Chandra Kishore Shwetanshu	Injurī Bhar Sinhorvā	1977; Samiksha Prakashan, Sitamarhi	Collection of songs and poems
Yogendra Rai	Bajjika Vyākaraṇa	1987; Shailesh Bhushan, Hajipur	Grammar

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Within this historical development, Dr Rameshwar Prasad plays the role not merely of a collector but of a guardian of cultural inheritance. In *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt*, the songs of village farmers, workers and women, including people with little or no formal education, bring popular life vividly before us. While formally cultivated literature may privilege artifice and intellectuality, the folk songs discussed here seem to flow like a natural spring of emotional and musical beauty.

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and intellectuality, the folk songs discussed here seem to flow like a natural spring of emotional and musical beauty.

Society in the Mirror of Folk Music: Musical Expressions of Ritual and the Life Cycle · Society, Rituals and the Musical Life Cycle

The fundamental spirit of a society lives in its folk songs. Bajjika songs, substantially represented in *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt*, give musical expression to the entire human life cycle. Across Mithila and Tirhut, significant occasions in human life are traditionally marked by ritual and song. There is a rich repertoire for birth, *upanayana* or sacred-thread initiation, and marriage, among the life-cycle rites recognised in Indian tradition.

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In an agricultural society, childbirth may signify both the continuity of the family and an increase in economic capacity; its joy is expressed through *sohar* and *khelaunā* songs. Yet these are not merely celebrations. Sociological and psychological reading reveals the pain of childbirth, life's victory over the fear of death, and the realities of family relations, including the teasing and conflicts between a husband's sister and his wife. By giving musical form to the physical and mental suffering of the woman in labour, society affords her a kind of psychological refuge.

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The songs of marriage rites are a crowning achievement of Bajjika folklore. From erecting the wedding canopy through worship at the altar, the application of vermilion, the *kohbar* chamber, songs of instruction and finally the daughter's departure, each rite has its distinctive song. The sorrow-laden songs of farewell employ comparisons and imaginative figures of extraordinary richness, sometimes difficult to match even in epics. The popular poet portrays the father as Lake Manasarovar, the mother-in-law as a brimming stepwell, the mother as the flowing Ganga and the husband as the rising sun. Such metaphors reveal the inventive

powers of popular imagination and its sense that human relationships are at one with nature. In farewell songs, the father's tears bring floods to the Ganga, the mother's tears darken the sky, and the brother's tears soak his garment down to the feet. These hyperboles are deeply moving, capable of softening even a hardened heart. They show how deeply the idea of the daughter as another family's property can wound a woman in patriarchal society.

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Nature, Agriculture and Labour Culture: Feminist Readings of Seasonal Songs and Jatsari · Nature, Farming and the Labour Culture of Songs

The Bajjika-speaking region depends heavily upon agriculture, and its folk literature therefore follows the rhythms of nature and the cycle of seasons. Seasonal change becomes an image of changing human emotion rather than a mere shift in weather. In Phagun and Chaitra, when the *rabi* crops are ready and nature seems in full bloom, Holi and Chaiti songs express celebration, sensual delight and earthly love. The affection of Radha and Krishna or Rama and Sita is often freed from a purely divine framework and recast as that of an ordinary farming couple.

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After the heat of Jeth, when the rains arrive, *kajri* and *pāvas* songs begin to resound. On the dark, cloud-filled nights of Sawan and Bhadon, a heroine waiting for her migrant husband may feel the night biting like a serpent. Yet the coolness of feeling in such songs descends like nectar upon people exhausted by struggle and labour. This identification of natural season and human love is presented as a distinguishing excellence of the Bajjika musical tradition.

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Work songs, particularly *jatsari*, sung while grinding grain on a handmill, and *ropani*, sung while transplanting rice, are invaluable elements of Bajjika folk literature. They ease labour but also articulate social realities. The friction of the grinding stones accompanies the woman's pain, conflict between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law, her precarious position within patriarchy, and remembered narratives of women seeking to preserve their dignity during historical invasions by Mughals and Turks. Feminist critical discourse analysis reveals that although male authority shapes the social order and popular sayings often portray women as weak or inferior, work songs such as *jatsari* create a protected space for women's quiet rebellion. In song they can raise their voices against their oppressors. Thus the source argues that a concern with women's resistance is not a recent import from the West but has long existed in the popular singing traditions of the region.

Work songs, particularly *jatsari*, sung while grinding grain on a handmill, and *ropani*, sung while transplanting rice, are invaluable elements of Bajjika folk literature. They ease labour but also articulate social realities. The friction of the grinding stones accompanies the woman's pain, conflict between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law, her precarious position within patriarchy, and remembered narratives of women seeking to preserve their dignity during historical invasions by Mughals and Turks. Feminist critical discourse analysis reveals that although male authority shapes the social order and popular sayings often portray women as weak or inferior, work songs such as *jatsari* create a protected space for women's quiet rebellion. In song they can raise their voices against their oppressors. Thus the source argues that a concern with women's resistance is not a recent import from the West but has long existed in the popular singing traditions of the region.

Marginalised Voices and Mythic Consciousness: Ballads and Environmental Criticism · The Marginalised and the Environment in Folk Narrative

Bajjika folklore is not confined to the rites of prosperous or high-status groups; it also gives forceful expression to marginalised, neglected and Dalit communities. Particularly important are the ballads of Dina and Bhadri, folk deities associated with the Musahar and other agricultural labouring castes. The two brothers are remembered as having struggled against feudal oppression and forced labour and as having sacrificed their lives. Their stories are popular in Mithila, the Bajjika region and Nepal's Terai, where they are sung as narratives of *manukhdev*, divinity embodied in human beings.

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An ecological reading of these ballads suggests that Dina and Bhadri are not merely heroes of a particular community but figures associated with environmental protection. Their struggle against feudal lords concerns rights over water bodies, ponds and forest resources. Powerful female characters, including Kama Mai and Somaro Dhani, are represented as defenders of agriculture, particularly rice cultivation. The environmental consciousness of this Dalit folk literature shows how Bajjika traditions embrace the mythic narratives, conflicts and relationships to nature of different social groups. Preserving and performing these ballads helps marginalised communities assert dignity and collective identity.

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An Analytical Study of Linguistic and Grammatical Relations between Bajjika and Central Maithili · A Comparison of Bajjika and Standard Maithili

A complete assessment of *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* requires a scientific understanding of its language and grammatical structure. Bajjika has been classified in linguistics as "Western Maithili" and is considered part of a broader Maithili dialect continuum. Nevertheless it differs in certain grammatical, phonological and morphological features from Central Maithili, commonly treated as the standard; linguists such as Abhishek Kumar Kashyap have studied these distinctions. The differences contribute to its recognisable regional linguistic identity.

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For an objective linguistic analysis, the following table compares principal grammatical features of Bajjika and Central Maithili.

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Grammatical / Linguistic Feature	Bajjika (Western Maithili)	Central / Standard Maithili
First Person Pronoun	Commonly uses ham	Uses ham and also frequently mai / maĕ
Verb Agreement / Transitivity	The verb form can encode up to two discourse referents (for example, subject and object) simultaneously	Complex agreement can encode up to three referents (for example, subject, object and recipient)
Phonology	Distinct pronunciation of aspirated and unaspirated consonants; pervasive nasalisation	Uses aspiration, with a comparatively different and more restrained distribution of nasalisation
Syntax	SOV order, e.g. Rām ghar jā rahal hai / sōṭā bhutley gelai hin	Also SOV, but with different auxiliary verb forms
Honorifics	Verb forms change according to forms of address such as āp, ahā̃, tū	Highly elaborate honorific agreement depending on the social standing of speaker, addressee and third person
Consonant Gemination	Greater tendency towards gemination, e.g. /majjil/ and /hammar/	Gemination is present but phonologically different

Analysis of Bajjika vocabulary reveals a rich combination of *tatsama* words borrowed directly from Sanskrit, *tadbhava* forms evolved from earlier Indo-Aryan sources, and indigenous or local words. The last are understood here as words formed within popular local usage without a direct Sanskrit or foreign derivation. Rural workers and farmers,

including people without formal schooling, use such expressions abundantly. Idioms such as “the belly swelling” (*ḍhīṛ phulānā*, to be pregnant) and “a poor man's wife is everybody's sister-in-law” (*nimlā ke maugī sabke bhaujāī*, meaning the poor person's dignity is an easy target of ridicule) reveal both the social realities and figurative richness of Bajjika speech.

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The vocabulary used in Dr Rameshwar Prasad's *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* indicates that the boundary between Bajjika and Maithili is very narrow. At the same time, local vocabulary and verb forms give Bajjika a distinctive regional fragrance.

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Part Four: A Multidimensional Research Framework for Bajjika Folk Literature and Linguistics

Bajjika is the mother tongue of large populations in both Nepal and India. To protect it against the pressures of globalisation and modernity, and to establish its academic significance, collection alone is not enough. The songs assembled by Dr Rameshwar Prasad and the wider corpus of Bajjika oral literature must also be analysed scientifically, linguistically and sociologically. A detailed interdisciplinary research framework is therefore essential.

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1. Principal Research Objectives and Hypotheses · 1. Objectives and Hypotheses

Objective 1—Textual and thematic inquiry: identify and classify systematically the social, familial, gender-related and environmental themes embedded in the folk songs collected by Dr Rameshwar Prasad and other scholars.

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Objective 2—Grammatical and linguistic mapping: compare the Bajjika vocabulary, verb forms, case markers and syntax used in the songs with Central Maithili, Bhojpuri and Magahi, and codify the distinctive grammatical regularities of Bajjika.

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Objective 3—Feminist and marginalised perspectives: decode representations of women's independence, patriarchal influence and the voices of marginalised groups, especially in *jatsari*, *sohar* and narrative ballads such as those of Dina and Bhadri.

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Objective 4—Digital preservation and computational linguistics: develop means of preserving this endangered intangible cultural heritage digitally and create corpora suitable for natural language processing (NLP).

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2. Theoretical Framework

The research will be undertaken in the light of the following modern approaches.

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Feminist critical discourse analysis (FCDA): examine how women are represented in Bajjika folk songs and idioms. Are they depicted merely as dutiful daughters and wives, or do work songs also record their resistance to patriarchy?

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Ecocriticism: investigate the interrelationship of people and nature, the conservation of forests and the importance of water resources in seasonal songs, agricultural songs such as *ropani*, and the Dina–Bhadri ballads.

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Sociolinguistics: study the relationship between language and society, particularly how Bajjika gives cultural identity to speakers in Vaishali, Muzaffarpur, Sitamarhi and Nepal's Terai, and how modern pressures are rendering the language vulnerable among younger generations.

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3. Research Methodology and Techniques · 3. Methodology

The investigation will proceed through four successive phases.

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Phase One: Text Collection, Thematic Coding and Semantic Analysis · Phase One: Collection, Coding and Interpretation of Texts

Songs will first be gathered from primary sources including Dr Rameshwar Prasad's *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* and *Bajjika Lokgīt*, and Nirmal Milind's *Tarahāttī Par Taregan*.

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They will be classified by occasion—life-cycle rites, seasons, labour and religion—and subjected to qualitative data analysis.

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Similes, metaphors and idioms in the songs will be identified and analysed for their cultural and figurative meanings.

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Phase Two: Morphosyntactic and Phonological Analysis · Phase Two: Linguistic, Morphological and Syntactic Analysis

The songs' lexical verbs and auxiliaries will be examined in detail. The study will analyse aspirated sounds, nasalisation and consonant gemination, including phonological features that distinguish Bajjika from Maithili.

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Honorific expressions and their grammatical effects will be studied in relation to social stratification. This requires examining power relations between speakers and listeners.

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Phase Three: Ethnographic, Spatial and Historical Study · Phase Three: Fieldwork and Historical Ethnography

Fieldwork will compare the book's cultural references with contemporary life in the Tirhut region—particularly Muzaffarpur and Vaishali—and Nepal's Terai.

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The historical influence of *biraha*, *bidesiya* and Ambapali, the celebrated courtesan of Vaishali, will be investigated. The relationship between Ramvriksha Benipuri's play *Ambapali* and Bajjika folk culture will be examined through historical evidence.

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The similarities and differences between Bajjika songs and Bhikhari Thakur's *Bidesiya* tradition will be analysed.

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Phase Four: Digitisation, Language-Conservation Strategy and Corpus Building · Phase Four: Digital Preservation and Corpus Creation

In keeping with the objectives of the Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL) and the Bharatavani project, these written folk songs will be recorded in audio and audiovisual formats to establish a digital linguistic corpus.

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Computational-linguistics methods will be used to design part-of-speech tagging for Bajjika vocabulary and to prepare a framework for a reliable trilingual Bajjika–Maithili–Hindi dictionary.

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4. Expected Outcomes and Academic Contributions · 4. Anticipated Results and Scholarly Value

The proposed research would do more than bring renewed attention to Dr Rameshwar Prasad's *Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt* as a literary work; it would also reinforce the cultural identity and dignity of more than ten million speakers in the Bajjika-speaking region, as the source estimates.

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It would demonstrate in academic settings that the range of human experience, philosophical depth and poetic beauty present in Bajjika songs are no less valuable than those of an established classical or written literature.

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For students and researchers of linguistics it would provide a dependable reference demonstrating that the relationship between Bajjika and

Maithili involves not merely dialectal labels but continuous historical language development.

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For policymakers and educational institutions, including Bihar University at Muzaffarpur, it would supply a substantial basis for introducing Bajjika literature into undergraduate and postgraduate teaching.

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Conclusion · Concluding Remarks

Bajjika Gīt-Saṅgīt, edited by Dr Rameshwar Prasad, is not merely a printed collection of folk songs. It is a historical document that gives words to the soil and climate of Tirhut and Mithila and to the beating hearts of their people. The pain of an aunt or sister-in-law turning the grinding stone, the restless yearning of a woman singing *kajri* amid the showers of Sawan, the joy that follows childbirth and its pain, and the tears of a daughter departing from her wedding pavilion all express experiences shared across humanity.

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This research framework insists that folk literature should not be seen only as sentiment, old custom or the colourful pleasures of village life. It requires serious academic, linguistic, ecological and sociological analysis. Bajjika and its rich musical inheritance constitute an invaluable element of world literature, with the pulse of an entire era preserved in each page and each voice. Scientific research of the kind proposed could give Bajjika and the larger Maithili literary world a new, authoritative and dignified presence on the global stage. Protecting this intangible inheritance from disappearance and preserving it for future generations is a collective responsibility.

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47. *Kuṇḍaliyā* in Laldas's *Mithila Ramayana* and Metrical Breaks Introduced through Editorial or Proofreading Ignorance

Abstract

Understand that about ninety-five per cent of the work is in *chaupāī*, while the remaining portion uses metres such as *rūpmālā* and *gītikā*. I am concerned here, however, with the *kuṇḍaliyā*. Although this metre occurs only rarely, it has impressed me deeply. The character of *kuṇḍaliyā* resembles that of the *rubāī*, and anyone who has read the quatrains of Omar Khayyam may come to love it.

Keywords: Laldas · Mithila Ramayana · kuṇḍaliyā · doha · rola · quantitative metre · broken metre · textual criticism

1

Doha

Rola

Kundaliya

2

Kundaliya Doha (Maithili Akademi edition)

Seeing Vibhishana in distress, Raghunayak, abode of compassion,

Granted him the royal estate in token of his pledge; keep the mind absorbed at his feet.

Keep the mind absorbed at his feet, protector of the lowly and the destitute;

Kind to those who seek refuge, the merciful one who dispels Lal's sorrows.

Even guardians of the world, Yama and Time, tremble at the sight of his unfailing arrows;

He is Lord Raghunayak, who frees all the worlds from sorrow. [1]

The tale of Raghupati destroys evil; merely hearing it banishes sorrow;

The Lord remains gracious to his devotees and fulfils their wishes.

He fulfils their wishes and always protects them from the cruel;

He increases their wealth, family, victory, glory, fortune and happiness.

He saves them from desire and its companions and bestows undying devotion;

The Ganga, called *Aghayāśinī* here, removes all their sin and suffering. [2]

Why should the mind, that moon-loving bird, forever taste the burning coals of worldly objects?

Better worship Sita and Rama, and eat the nectar of the fruit of action.

Take the fruit as nectarous food, laying aside the burden of the world;

The devotee attains the supreme Brahman, breaking the fetters of becoming.

Even the fallen may find a way and proper happiness wherever they remain;

Know your own certain good; the other pleasures of worldly objects are unfitting. [3]

O bird of the mind, why suffer so much inside the cage of worldly existence?

Hold fast, says Lal, to the sheltering tree of the Lord's feet if you seek happiness.

Find shelter beneath that tree and sing Rama's story every day;

There is no better means for protection, welfare and salvation.

Countless sinners have crossed the ocean of existence without pausing for a moment;

Sing the story of Hari according to your capacity, keeping the mind single. [4]

The text above is taken from the edition published by the Maithili Akademi.

3

Counting Quantitative Metre

Let us consider Maithili pronunciation, the rules of reading, and the distinction between short and long vowels.

Learn the distinction between *guru* (heavy) and *laghu* (light) syllables in classical prosody.

Among the thirteen vowels, *a, i, u, ṛ* and *ḷ* are described as short, and *ā, ī, ū, ṝ* (printed thus in the source), *e, ai, o* and *au* as long. When a vowel is joined to a consonant, a syllabic written character (*guṇitākṣara*) is formed: *k* + *a* = *ka*; *k* + *ā* = *kā*. A vowel or a consonant joined to a vowel constitutes a syllable; an isolated consonant does not. Thus *avāk* has two syllables, *a* and *vā*. (1) All short vowels and syllables formed with them are light (*laghu*), signified by U. (2) All long vowels and syllables formed with them are heavy (*guru*), signified by a short horizontal stroke above. (3) Syllables with *anusvāra* or *visarga* are heavy. (4) A syllable followed by a conjunct consonant or an isolated consonant is counted as heavy; in *ac* and *satya*, the syllables *a* and *sa* are heavy in this account.

Having said that anusvara and visarga make a syllable heavy, we must now add that a short vowel together with chandrabindu is counted as short.

That is: chandrabindu + short vowel = one *mātrā*.

Conjunct consonants: here the quantitative units are counted as follows.

kti = *k* + *t* + *i* = 0 + 0 + 1 = 1.

ktī = *k* + *t* + *ī* = 0 + 0 + 2 = 2.

kṣa = *k* + *ṣa* = 0 + 1.

tra = *t* + *ra* = 0 + 1.

jña = *j* + *ña* = 0 + 1.

śra = *ś* + *ra* = 0 + 1.

sra = *s* + *ra* = 0 + 1.

śṛ = *ś* + *ṛ* = 0 + 1.

tva = *t* + *va* = 0 + 1.

ttva = *t* + *t* + *va* = 0 + 0 + 1.

Short vowel + avagraha (ऽ) = 1 + 0.

The *bikārī* sign should not be used after *a* or a long vowel: forms such as *dia′*, *ā′* and *o′* are defective. It can, however, follow a consonant plus short *a*.

Short vowel + chandrabindu = 1 + 0.

Long vowel + chandrabindu = 2 + 0.

For example, *hãsal* = 1 + 1 + 1.

Sā̃s = 2 + 1.

The *bikārī* sign and chandrabindu are assigned zero additional units.

Jā ka′ = 2 + 1.

k (the bare consonant) = 0.

ka = *k* + *a* = 0 + 1.

Since a tendency has arisen in Maithili to pronounce *ka* as bare *k*, the *bikārī* sign became necessary; there is no comparable need with long vowels.

U denotes a short syllable.

— denotes a long or heavy syllable.

One long unit (—) equals two short units (U + U).

4

Broken Metre

Let us now examine all four *kuṇḍaliyās* in Laldas's *Mithila Ramayana*. A disruption of metre is readily apparent. Surely Laldas himself would not have written defective metre. There is no obvious typing error here, however. The fault may therefore lie with a Maithili Akademi editor or proofreader unfamiliar with quantitative scansion who altered the text to standardise spelling, inadvertently damaging the metre. Ramdev Jha, editor of the Sahitya Akademi edition of Laldas's *Ramayana*, claimed that his text did not contain such metrical disruptions. In response to accusations that he had altered the original wording, he argued that his accusers did not understand quantitative metre. He claimed that his departures from the received text served to repair metrical defects. If Laldas wrote in the *kuṇḍaliyā* form, editors ought at least to know enough to recognise that giving a passage the heading "Kundaliya" is insufficient without preserving the metre itself. In Ramdev Jha's opinion, the Sahitya Akademi edition of Laldas's *Ramayana* should be regarded as the definitive text. Now consider that version.

Laldas's Kundaliya, Edited by Ramdev Jha (Sahitya Akademi)

Kundaliya Doha

> Seeing Vibhishana in distress, Raghunayak, abode of compassion,
> Granted him the royal estate in token of his pledge; keep the mind absorbed at his feet.
> Keep the mind absorbed at his feet, protector of the lowly and the destitute;
> Kind to those who seek refuge, the merciful one who dispels Lal's sorrows.

Even guardians of the world, Yama and Time, tremble at the sight of his unfailing arrows;
He is Lord Raghunayak, who frees all the worlds from sorrow. [1]
The tale of Raghupati destroys evil; merely hearing it banishes sorrow;
The Lord remains gracious to his devotees and fulfils their wishes.
He fulfils their wishes and always protects them from the cruel;
He increases their wealth, family, victory, glory, fortune and happiness.
He saves them from desire and its companions and bestows undying devotion;
The Ganga, called *Aghanāśinī* here, removes all their sin and suffering. [2]
Why should the mind, that moon-loving bird, forever taste the burning coals of worldly objects?
Better worship Sita and Rama, and eat the nectar of the fruit of action.
Take the fruit as nectarous food, laying aside the burden of the world;
The devotee attains the supreme Brahman, breaking the fetters of becoming.
Even the fallen may find a way and proper happiness wherever they remain;
Know your own certain good; the other pleasures of worldly objects are unfitting. [3]
O bird of the mind, why suffer so much inside the cage of worldly existence?
Hold fast, says Lal, to the sheltering tree of the Lord's feet if you seek happiness.
Find shelter beneath that tree and sing Rama's story every day;
There is no better means for protection, welfare and salvation.
Countless sinners have crossed the ocean of existence without pausing for a moment;
Sing the story of Hari according to your capacity, keeping the mind single. [4]

In fact there is very little difference between the Maithili Akademi text and this one: mostly case endings and two words have been joined or separated at a few places. In the last line of the second *kuṇḍaliyā*, the form *Aghayāśinī* has been changed to *Aghanāśinī*.

Gokarna in Karnataka lies by the Gangavali and the stream named *Adhanāśinī* in the source. In the line "the Ganga removes all their sins and suffering," the author argues that the form *Adhanāśinī* is appropriate, not *Aghanāśinī* (written *Aghnāsini* in this discussion), which he considers a possible typing error. This distinction and spelling are retained as stated in the original discussion.

Although the claim to have repaired the broken metre has not been substantiated, an effort has been made to use the appropriate word. For this

reason the Sahitya Akademi text seems preferable to the Maithili Akademi edition.

48. The First Pattern (Repetition) Poetry and Shape or Concrete Poetry in Maithili

Abstract

Poetry composed with a recurring pattern of line lengths is *pattern poetry*. It is a verse form organised around repetition. The repeated element need not be a sound; it may simply be the length of the lines.

Keywords: pattern poetry · repetition · shape poetry · concrete poetry · visual verse · experimentation

1

Pattern (Repetition) Poetry

Poetry written according to a pattern of line lengths is pattern or repetition poetry.

What is the metre of lines?

It is verse made with recurring arrangements. Repeated sounds are not necessary; the lengths of successive lines recur according to a pattern.

Example

Going, going
Going, going I travel to a far-off land from which I cannot return.
Many times before I have come back to this place.
I thought the road was only half the distance.
When I returned,
It was to depart once again towards a distant place,
To a country so far away that return was impossible.
Whoever tries to come back will tire halfway through half the road;
And whoever goes on will find the road disappearing.
I will leave behind no pathway and no
Familiar sign,
Nor abandon even a little hope.
The track after the halfway point, scrambling and breaking through,
And I, advancing as the vanishing road accomplished its work.
One task will now begin all over again,
With a new atmosphere and new people,

An experiment upon an experiment
May yield some unforeseen result,
Or push me still farther into that distant land;
And I shall not return again to my former country,
Where the old frightened people will no longer remain,
Nor the old and familiar trees and plants.
Proof of a consequence
Seems to have turned away from me.
New people and new trees and plants in this country,
No familiar sign, no hope, and no recognisable path.
2.

Shape or Concrete Poetry

Unlike pattern poetry, this kind of poem assumes the form of a visible shape. Instead of merely repeating line lengths, it places words into an image. The example below is arranged like a tree.

A Familiar Sign of Vanishing Hope
Seeing
Trees on both sides,
Moving alongside the road,
The shade of the trees deepens;
I think my recognition will grow denser and more certain, yet
T
H
I
C
K
E
N
I
N
G
Darkness grows thick and close,
The familiar signs of my hope disappear.

49. The Round-Necked Mahākavi Vidyāpati of the Padāvalī Before Jyotirīśvara, and the Turbaned Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura of Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha After Jyotirīśvara: Two Traditions

Abstract

Vidyāpati's Sanskrit works bear the attribution 'composed by Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati', and that Vidyāpati was a Brahmin. My concern is with the Vidyāpati of Maithili. I have discussed why a turban was placed upon his head and he was appropriated as 'our Vidyāpati'. This did not happen when non-Brahmin communities kept him alive for eight hundred years through the Bidāpat dance. It happened when Bengal claimed both Vidyāpati and Govindadās as its own, and when the Bengali scholar Rājkrishna Mukhopādhyāy was the first to say that Vidyāpati was a poet of Mithila's language, while Nagendranāth Gupta of Bengal first said that Govindadās too was a poet of that language. When these facts came to light, Bengal at first rose in furious opposition and subsequently accepted them.

Keywords: Jyotirīśvara; Vidyāpati; padāvalī; Avahaṭṭha; Sanskrit; parallel tradition; literary history

.....

Let us come to the central question. I have no doubt that the many Vidyāpatis who served as royal pandits or in religious offices—one of them also the son of a devadāsī—were Brahmins. But I am speaking not of Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura and his Kīrtilatā and Kīrtipatākā; I am speaking of the Vidyāpati Padāvalī. Let us keep the distinction clear. Consider the Bidāpat tradition sung by non-Brahmins. Its poet, I suggest, belonged to a barber caste and preceded Jyotirīśvara: evidence lies in the reference to this poet and his work in Jyotirīśvara's Varṇa-ratnākara.

Mahādeva was originally a deity of non-Brahmin communities and was gradually adopted by Brahmins. Nowhere in the poems of the Padāvalī does Vidyāpati refer to himself as a Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭha author. Above all, why does the sympathy for the dispossessed found in these poems not appear in the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha works of the other Vidyāpati, the Brahmin? Let us consider examples.

Mahākavi Vidyāpati

The earliest poet of Maithili, anterior to the poet-scholar Jyotirīśvara (c. 1275–1350), because Jyotirīśvara mentions him in his work. He is distinct from Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha writer.

Possibly the son of Śrī Maheś Ṭhakkura, of the barber caste, from Bisphī village.

The Vidyāpati Padāvalī has been danced and dramatised in Bidāpat performances of the parallel tradition since before Jyotirīśvara.

Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura (1350–1435), of the Bisphī–Kāśyapa branch of the Viṣaiwār lineage, was a court poet of King Śivasiṃha and an author in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha. His enduring works include Kīrtilatā, Kīrtipatākā, Puruṣaparīkṣā, Gorakṣavijaya, Likhanāvalī and many others. He is not, in this account, the same person as Maithili's earlier Vidyāpati.

Bodhi Kāyastha

Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura describes Bodhi Kāyastha's attainment of the Ganges (*gaṅgālābha*) in Puruṣaparīkṣā. The same story circulated about Mahākavi Vidyāpati, author of the pre-Jyotirīśvara Maithili Padāvalī; subsequently it came to be associated with Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha author.

Ugnā Mahādeva

Mahādeva, in the form of Ugnā, stayed with Vidyāpati as a servant so that he could hear his songs. The legend became attached to both Maithili's pre-Jyotirīśvara founding poet and Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha author at King Śivasiṃha's court.

2

'Mithila Sanskritik Parishad's Investiture of Vidyāpati with the Sacred Thread and the Ceremonial Pāg'

The Mithila Sanskritik Parishad and associates such as Kishorikānt Miśra either failed to understand—or did not wish to understand—the difference between the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura and the poet celebrated as the cuckoo of Maithili. Written historical evidence, I maintain, places Gonu Jhā in 1050–1150; yet Uṣā Kiran Khān makes him debate the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati in her Hindi historical novel *Sirjanhār* (published by Bharatiya Jnanpith). Vīrendra Jhā says Gonu Jhā lived five hundred years ago, while Tārānand Viyogī places him three hundred years ago—their Hindi books on Gonu Jhā appeared respectively from Rajkamal Prakashan and the National Book Trust. In Vibhā Rānī's Hindi book on Gonu Jhā (Vani Prakashan), Kunal puts him in the reign of Bhav Siṃha, in the fourteenth century. Such is the situation even though the written genealogical register places Gonu Jhā ten generations before the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati.

Had photographs of Jagdish Prasad Mandal not survived, Kishorikānt Miśra's reactionary Mithila Sanskritik Parishad would have invested him too with the sacred thread, placed a pāg upon his head, and repeated the very act it performed upon Vidyāpati a thousand years later. It would have

pointed to some old earthen mound in Burma and proclaimed it the imaginary ancestral homestead of Jagdish Prasad 'Jhā/Ṭhakkura'.

The abuse hurled by Malangiyā's son, Ramdev Jhā's son and numerous pseudonymous persons has also appeared in *Videha* without expurgation, so that readers can judge for themselves. Only certain insults impossible to publish have been withheld. Fear of abuse is also why historians of Maithili and Mithila have hinted at this issue but never pursued it.

Thus, I argue, the poet was indeed the Vidyāpati who preceded Jyotirīśvara (1275–1350). The song-and-dance tradition of Jayadeva (c. 1200) and of kīrtaniyā performance accords with the pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati Padāvalī, not with the poetic form of Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati.

Let us return to the platform of the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, from which Ramlochan Ṭhakkura made his statement in a manner suited to that platform. The Parishad did not perform Vidyāpati's sacred-thread ceremony: it performed Maithili's sacred-thread ceremony. With the pāg it placed on Vidyāpati, it erased Bindhyeśvar Maṇḍal and Śrīkānt Maṇḍal from Kolkata and completed the ritual appropriation of Maithili.

Consider some instances of caste orthodoxy in the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati:

Kīrtilatā: marriage between castes and non-castes is condemned as base and transgressive.

In *Puruṣaparīkṣā*, Vidyāpati interrupts the narrative to make an authorial pronouncement that Rajput women lack character. This is comparable, I argue, to the statement in the Atharvaveda that someone may seize the wife of a Śūdra by the hand without her consent. The Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati lays special emphasis on caste and non-caste; purity of blood and caste matter greatly to him. He declares that a person of low birth deserves no mercy, and that beauty is the monopoly of the wealthy and privileged. He treats caste as the final determinant of social life and a person born into a bad lineage as no more than a snake with a vicious mind. He calls a country in which caste regulations are not enforced a land of *mlecchas* (see Upendra Thakur, *Aspects of Society and Economy of Medieval Mithila*). This is the Vidyāpati whom Kishorikānt Miśra's Mithila Sanskritik Parishad would dress in sacred thread and pāg.

'The great ancestors were all of my own caste.'
'Until the mālatī unfolds its bloom,
The bee cannot revel in its sweetness.'
And:
'What nectar could there be in an unopened bud?'

3

Phanishwarnath Renu wrote a reportage on Bidāpat dance that appeared in the weekly *Vishvamitra* on 1 August 1945. The account matters because it was written some seven hundred years after Jyotirīśvara's description of the subject, and records the parallel tradition that kept Vidyāpati alive through those centuries.

Yet Vidyāpati was unexpectedly wrested from the people who had sustained him. Bideśvar Ṭhakkura, singing Vidyāpati's songs and protesting that Brahmins had taken the poet by putting a pāg on him, died with that anguish. Kānungo Badri Prasad Ṭhakkura of Brahmapurā, Binod Ṭhakkura of Pokharbhīṛā, Saryug Ṭhakkura of Rudrapur, Jairām Ṭhakkura of Meṃhath, and the whole village of Bisphī still repeat the charge. Śāligrām Yādav and Avadhiyā Ṭhakkura bear witness to Bisphī's tradition. A host of fanciful arguments about Vidyāpati's birth and background accompanied this ritual appropriation, but scarcely a research paper even mentioned his parallel tradition. I dedicate this essay to the thousands who, like Bideśvar Ṭhakkura, kept Vidyāpati alive between the accounts of Jyotirīśvara and Phanishwarnath Renu.

Mithila's Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa Tradition and Its Parallel Tradition

Following Madhav Siṃha's 1760 order concerning the branch genealogical registers (*śākhā-pañjī*), a new cult of pedigree spread among Mithila's Brahmins and Kāyasthas. It produced the *battesagamiyā* or *bhalmānas* subdivision among Karṇa Kāyasthas and the *śrotriya* subdivision among Maithil Brahmins. According to this critique, physical and mental illness increased alarmingly in these groups, as did polygamy, child marriage and the number of widows. The speed and peacefulness of these changes were compatible with what was presented as the mainstream Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa tradition.

Views of Dineśvar Lāl Ānand and Rāmvṛkṣ Benīpurī on Vidyāpati

Dineśvar Lāl Ānand was misled. In those days the genealogical registers were confidential; in them the Bisphī branch of the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati, identified as Viṣaiwār, had been classed as the lower-ranking Jaiwār. Branch registers did not exist before 1760; the evidence, I submit, is that the later generations of Ayāchi Miśra's original lineage appear both among Śrotriyas and within another Brahmin subdivision. It is rather like finding a bull but no cow depicted on the seals of the Indus Valley civilisation: how, one asks, could the bull have come into existence without the cow? Ānand lacked full access to the genealogical data. Perhaps, influenced by propaganda that identified the Padāvalī poet with the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha author, he thought the classification of Viṣaiwār Bisphī as Jaiwār could explain why Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura became a revolutionary by writing in Avahaṭṭha. Yet Ānand admits that there is

neither a manuscript of the Padāvalī in Vidyāpati's own hand nor even evidence of a collection of those songs made in his lifetime. How is that possible, when the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati opens and closes his books with expansive declarations about the kings, queens and patrons who inspired him and under whose protection he worked? He has a full authorial confidence, a command of both Sarasvatī and Lakṣmī. Why, then, is the Padāvalī silent? Ānand has no answer. The Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati writes about his patrons but says nothing of himself in those works. He even shows discomfort in writing Avahaṭṭha, then a literary language of the mainstream. But the pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati was so influential that he had to include Maithili songs in his Sanskrit drama *Gorakṣavijaya*—just as Jyotirīśvara, the earliest reporter of Bidāpat, had to include Maithili songs in his Sanskrit drama *Dhūrttasamāgama*.

Govind Jhā detects Vidyāpati's tradition in Jyotirīśvara's description of Bidāpat and even discusses it. Why, then, does he not pursue the possibility of the earlier Vidyāpati while Bideśvar Ṭhakkura is singing himself to death? How does the place at which Vidyāpati feels thirsty in a play become the playwright's own village? Everyone writes a play about 'our Vidyāpati' to serve a different claim.

Rāmvṛkṣ Benīpurī likewise lacked the evidence of the genealogical registers. From the construction of a subdivision and a legend he wrote derisively about Keśav Miśra's treatment of Vidyāpati. This Keśav Miśra, of the *Dvaita Pariśiṣṭa*, was a grandson of Vācaspati II (1400–1490). Another Keśav Miśra, who lived around 1150, wrote *Tarkabhāṣā*, which was reviewed in *Tarkaprakāśa* by Vardhamān, son of Gaṅgeśa, author of *Tattvacintāmaṇi*. Benīpurī advanced not a single step beyond the research Ananda Coomaraswamy had undertaken in 1915; nor, a century later, has another mainstream scholar done so. Benīpurī retells the Ugnā legend but is silent on whether Mahādeva would dance on Kailāsa to the orthodox Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati's *Śaivasarvasvasāra* or to the pre-Jyotirīśvara poet's *nacārī* songs. Like Coomaraswamy, he knows that a *Bhāgavata* in the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati's hand exists and has heard how the Ganges absorbed Vidyāpati in his *gaṅgālābha*. Like Coomaraswamy, he has heard of *Puruṣaparīkṣā* without reading it; otherwise he would know that its Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha author tells the *gaṅgālābha* story about Bodhi Kāyastha. That story, like the legend of Ugnā, circulated about the pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati and was later ritually attached to the other poet: the tale of Bodhi Kāyastha in *Puruṣaparīkṣā* is the evidence. Benīpurī even calls *Kīrtipatākā* a collection of Maithili songs. Is research done by hearsay? Why has an exhausted mainstream been unable to develop the foundation Coomaraswamy laid a century ago? Because the dominant Śatapatha-Brāhmaṇa orthodoxy does not permit it. Yet scholars assert without evidence that Purāditya, a friend of Śivasiṃha,

was a Bhūmihār Brahmin, just as Ramānāth Jhā called Govindadās (Jhā) a Śrotriya (a claim Sukumar Sen found ridiculous), Ramdev Jhā pronounced him a Brahmin, and Vermaji, writing in the Laldās commemorative volume, pronounced Kālidāsa a Kāyastha.

The Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati frames the opening and closing of his books with ritual observances and the names of royal and other patrons, but not an account of himself. Why, then, did the Padāvalī remain on the people's lips rather than receive the elaborate bookish treatment he gave his other writings? Because its songs had been composed centuries before him, before the pāg came into use in Mithila. Names such as Rūpnārāyaṇ, Śivasiṃha, Lakhimā, Dev Siṃha, Har Siṃha, Padma Siṃha, Viśvās Dev, Arjun-Amar, Rāghav Siṃha, Rudra Siṃha, Dhīr Siṃha, Bhairav Siṃha and Chandra Siṃha were later inserted, audibly disturbing the rhythm of the songs. The Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati's *Bhūparikramā* (Dev Siṃha), *Kīrtilatā* (Kīrti Siṃha and Vīr Siṃha), *Kīrtipatākā*, *Gorakṣavijaya* (Śivasiṃha), *Likhanāvalī* (Purāditya) and *Dānavākyāvalī* (Queen Dhīrmatī) are manifestly court-sponsored works. *Gorakṣavijaya*, written for the worship of Bhairava, contains Maithili songs like those in *Dhūrttasamāgama*: another indication, in my view, of the earlier Vidyāpati's overwhelming influence. Had the names not differed, people would have identified Jyotirīśvara himself as the poet who preceded him.

Gaṅgeśa, author of *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, produced one work said to equal twelve thousand treatises. Professor Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in *History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila*: 'The family which was inferior in social status is now extinct in Mithila... Gangesha's family is completely ignored and we are not expected to know even his father's name.' Bhattacharya says Professor R. Jhā (Ramānāth Jhā) supplied this information.

Now consider the genealogical records. They expressly state, I argue, that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death and married a woman of the leatherworking community. Why did Ramānāth Jhā conceal this information from Bhattacharya? A particular caste subdivision circulated the story of Gaṅgeśa's rise from fool to scholar and, I allege, conspired to erase him.

Gaṅgeśa's son Vardhamān called his father *sukavi-kairava-kānana-induḥ*, the moon shining upon the water lilies of good poetry. Under what scheme, then, have the poems of a scholar as renowned as Gaṅgeśa disappeared? The preceding examples, I contend, explain this. Vāsudeva of Bengal was a fellow-student of Pakṣadhar Miśra. He came to study in Mithila, passed the *śalākā* examination and earned the title Sārvabhauma. He memorised the verses of Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* and Udayana's *Nyāyakusumāñjali*. Pakṣadhar and other teachers in Mithila would not

permit the *Tattvacintāmaṇi* to be copied. Vāsudeva's disciple Raghunāth Śiromaṇi defeated his teacher Pakṣadhar Miśra in debate and obtained the right to demonstrate a proof. Vāsudeva and Raghunāth founded the Navya-Nyāya school at Navadvīpa. Pakṣadhar Miśra was a contemporary of the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati. With Raghunāth, the arrival of Bengali students in Mithila ceased.

Grierson called the Bisphī copperplate that Śivasiṃha granted to the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati a forgery. He was familiar with the Padāvalī and believed that its poet could not have received such a grant. The plate, however, had been bestowed upon the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha writer, a distinction Grierson did not consider. Mahāmahopādhyāya Haraprasad Shastri recognised the difference and regarded the copperplate as authentic.

Śrīdharadās's *Saduktikarṇāmṛta* includes the fisherman Kaivarta Papīhā's hymn to the Ganges and songs of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa. Dhoyī, a weaver, was a court poet of Lakṣmaṇsen. Lakhimā Ṭhākurāin wrote verse in Sanskrit, not the Padāvalī (Grierson). A record of Śrīdharadās survives at Andhrāṭhāṛhī; he was a minister under Nānyadev and Gaṅgadev. His descendant Amiyakar was contemporary with the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati. Upendra Thakur considers Gaṅgadev a Kalachuri. Vijay Kumar Thakur identifies the Vidyāpati song in Śrīdharadās's *Saduktikarṇāmṛta* with praise of the Kalachuri Karṇa. Rādhākṛṣṇa Chaudhary takes a different view. In any case, I argue, this Vidyāpati preceded Jyotirīśvara. In connection with the *Rāmacarita* and Vigrahapāla III's defeat of Karṇa, Rādhākṛṣṇa Chaudhary found two Pāla inscriptions at Naulāgaṛh, about sixteen kilometres north of Begusarai. That Karṇa, too, belongs to the eleventh century. *Dhūrttasamāgama* is famous in South India as well.

Appendix I

Phanishwarnath Renu

Vidyāpati of a Folk Song

Introduction

While researching Mahākavi Vidyāpati, I felt that a chapter ought to be called 'Vidyāpati, Poet of Cultivators, Field Labourers and Cart Drivers'. For in the Purnea–Saharsa region, even today there are troupes that sing the Padāvalī, act out its emotions and dance. Their leaders are generally buffalo riders, cowherds or drivers of bullock carts. I asked Maithil pandits about this.

'How did it happen?' They replied: 'What business are you getting into? It is because of these fools that Vidyāpati is in such a sorry state today.

Whenever these ordinary people fancy it, they add four more songs in Vidyāpati's name. You are being led astray.' Ignoring the prohibitions of Mithila's pandits, I gladly began preparations to visit Saharsa. Kanchīrā is a village governed by the district magistrates of two districts: half of it is in Saharsa, the other half in Purnea.

People in both districts speak of Kanchīrā's Vidyāpati troupe. On the day I arrived, a remarkable incident had occurred. A politician who had represented the area for ten years had been soundly defeated in an election. A night of singing and dancing might therefore be interpreted politically, and the troupe's leader, Janakdās, refused permission to perform.

The next night, after much entreaty, he relented. After lengthy argument, circling the point and repeating himself, Janakdās claimed that the Vidyāpati dance had first originated in his own family, but he would never say more. When he was satisfied that I had not come to extract a thousand or two thousand rupees from the government treasury in the troupe's name, he struck the mṛdaṅga. I watched the performance all night. A boy who grazed cattle put on a sari and became Rādhā, bereft of her beloved, and sang in tears: 'How many days must I pass without Hari, an abandoned woman all alone?' The next day I again asked Janakdās about the dance's origins. 'Who knows how long the hereditary lead-singing of this dance has passed down through my family?' he answered. What troubled him was my tape recorder: 'You secretly filled your tape with every song. Cleverly you got your work done for nothing, didn't you?' Even after I paid him fifty rupees, he would not tell me when or how cultivators, labourers, cowherds and cart drivers had begun singing and dancing to Vidyāpati's verses. I lay on the straw in Janakdās's shelter all day and felt he had no pity. His young widowed daughter spoke on my behalf, but he remained unmoved: 'You want to have the secrets that would make a laughing-stock of my family printed in the Gazette?' Old Janakdās untethered the oxen and went to graze them. I stayed in his shelter and then heard a tale—or dreamed a dream—or fell into some delusion. I cannot say which.

Appendix 2

Bidāpat Dance (original reportage by Phanishwarnath Renu; Maithili adaptation by Madhupnāth Jhā)

Bidāpat Dance

It is supposed that this dance originated in Darbhanga district. There is little need to describe its present condition in its own birthplace. Yet it is still valued in villages of certain North Bihar districts and in parts of Bhagalpur and Purnea. It has come to be regarded as a dance of the 'little people'; members of so-called polite society regard watching it as beneath

them. But at weddings, tonsure ceremonies and other festivities among Musahars, Dhāṅgaṛs and Dusādhs, it remains an event of great excitement. Seven or eight performers take part, with only two instruments: the mṛdaṅga and the manjīrā cymbals.

Come, then, let us enjoy the Bidāpat dance, setting aside our respectability for a while.

Dhṛṅg dhā, dhṛṅg dhā, tinnā—the mṛdaṅga sounded until it seemed to speak. *Kun kun kun kun*—the cymbals joined it.

'Gaṇanāyakaṃ phaladāyakaṃ paṇḍitam patitam...' Do not laugh, all of you. That was the opening invocation, in pure Sanskrit.

Dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā—the mṛdaṅga began again.

Kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ—the manjīrā kept pace.

The dancers began circling the assembled musicians and spectators on every side. Behind them Bipatā spun like a top, contorting his face and crying, 'Oy, oy, oy, oy!'

Dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī. The mṛdaṅga changed rhythm and produced another strain. *Kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ...* Enough now! I have made you dance quite enough; the story of the dance can wait.

The dancers gathered in one place and swayed. *Dhirināṅgi tintā, tiṭak-tiṭak dhā, tiṭakal gadagin dhā.* The rhythmic sequence and the dance ended. The performers pulled their veils down and sat among the audience. Bipatā, who had been playing the clown, began looking for the dancers. *Dhṛṅgā-dhṛṅgā...*

'Dhin-tinak tinak, dhin tinak-tinak'—the mṛdaṅga sounded.

The accompanists joined their voices.

'Here enters the tenderest of maidens,

Walking like a swan, Vṛṣabhānu's darling...'

The dancers rose and approached Bipatā, who joyfully began crying, 'Oy, oy, oy, oy!'

'Dhin-tinak tinak, dhin-tinak tinak.'

'Ah, body and mind are stirred by the wind together,

The moon rises above the lightning...'

The dancers cast their veils aside. At the sight of their moon-like faces—close-shaven beards, moustaches and ungainly, peculiar features—the audience roared with laughter. One dancer looked down, shrinking and moving like a sensitive plant in a display of maidenly shyness. Bipatā tried to attract the dancer's attention.

'Ah, the bride smiles when she sees her beloved,

And turns her bashful face away...'

The dancer smiled and turned away, exposing teeth blackened by chewing tobacco. Please, ladies and gentlemen, be quiet. Yes, yes, these may be songs from Vidyāpati's Padāvalī, but what we are watching is the *Bidāpat dance*.

Stop talking about New Theatres, *Vidyāpati*, Kanan Bala and Pahari Sanyal. I am beginning the last musical phrase.

How often must I explain that this is the Bidāpat dance? That dancer, Ṭahalu Pāswān, had a father who was a notorious bandit. His father was sentenced to transportation across the black waters, his mother went off with another man, and he began dancing as a child. In his youth he was the sensation of the locality—a tremendous sensation. So irresistible were his gestures that Parbatiyā abandoned her settled household and ran away with him one night. Yes, Ṭahalu Pāswān could sing:

'When my charming lover comes into the courtyard,
I shall turn and walk away with the faintest smile;
Kānh will try a hundred ways to win me...'
Dhṛnnā dhṛṅgā, tinā-tinnā—the mṛdaṅga shifted to a new rhythm.
Kinnā-kinnā—the cymbals changed their beat too.
'My friend...
My friend, why do you ask what I have experienced?'
'Since the beginning of life I have gazed on beauty,
Yet even now I am not satisfied.'

'Hey, silence! Silence!' Bipatā angrily tried to stop them. One of the accompanists began twisting his towel into a whip. Bipatā complained that beating him would only waste time: his back had grown thick-skinned after years of blows from the landlord's shoes. He had interrupted merely to ask whose beauty the singer had been gazing upon all his life. Once persuaded that the song meant his own face, he was delighted; immediately he drew a little mirror from his pocket and proudly studied himself.

The song ended. Now it was Bipatā Mahādeva's turn.

'Hey, leader!'

'Hmm?'

'Listen to me now.'

'Oh, father!
Oh, father, what misery have I not endured?
For seven years I paid interest,
Yet still I was not free of debt.

Like a bullock turning the oil press I worked day and night,
Yet the obligations only grew.
I sold my plate to pay the revenue clerk,
My drinking vessel to pay the village watchman,
I sold my goat to pay the policeman—
And now I am Fakṭanāth Girdhārī, stripped of everything.'

Did you understand anything? You yourselves are all Fakṭanāth Girdhārī. Just look at the spectators: whatever they have understood, they are laughing until their stomachs hurt.

Dhṛṅgā-dhṛṅgā, dhidhinnā tinnā...
'O friend!
The month of Bhādo, the clouds are swollen,
And my dwelling is empty...'

Beautiful, beautiful! Vidyāpati truly is the cuckoo of Mithila...

You are being swept away again; you are no better than Bipatā. However often you are asked not to, you cannot resist making a comment on every song, just as he does. And here comes Bipatā himself again.

'The month of Bhādo; the clouds pour down,
And the roof of my hut is leaking.'

'Ha-ha-ha!' The audience doubles over with laughter. I forgot to mention that Bipatā imagines himself both Kṛṣṇa and a lover setting out for foreign parts. Yet he never forgets that he is Kalaru Musahar of Halhaliyā, a human being whose social position, he feels, is no higher than that of a bullock at an oil press. When the dancers put their arms round his neck, feigning love, affection and wounded pride, and sing that Mādhava has forsaken them for a distant land, he forgets that he is Kṛṣṇa leaving Gokul for Mathurā. The inequalities of his own life begin dancing before him in bodily form, and he sings:

'The Ādrā rains did not fall, nor those of Āśleṣā;
Everywhere the fields look like an old woman's hair.
Fish and turtles have vanished underground;
My friend, will a terrible famine come?
A whole day's toil brings a single seer of paddy—
How can a life be kept alive on that?
Leaving you, beloved, I go to a foreign land.'

A moment later the dancers begin another song:

'She carries her beloved in her lap to market,
And the people ask: "Who is this man to you?"
"My mother-in-law's son, my sister-in-law's elder brother—

The husband written in my fate from long ago.'"

Now Bipatā clamours like a child for jalebis, batāshā sweets and toys.

Just then a dancer begins to sing:

'At the coming of dawn,
My husband returned to me.
With trembling hands he took my necklace against his breast;
With lotus hands he touched my bosom and looked upon my moon-like face.'

Bipatā interrupts and asks one of the accompanists to explain the meaning. The accompanist elaborates freely on the song: how the heroine had been sleeping on the straw in her hut when Bipatā arrived.

Let us turn to the audience. Strong young women with dark, sturdy bodies watch Bipatā intently, suppressing smiles, nudging one another and whispering with delight. Middle-aged women pretend to be angry and try to restrain them. But who can restrain stifled laughter or a heart that has been tickled? Meanwhile the dancers begin their refrain:

'Come, my heart, come, my heart, to my husband's home,
Let us go, O Rāma;
Ah, O Rāma, in my parents' house
I shall set a fire...'

The girls grow restless; electricity seems to race through the young men's veins. The dance is coming to an end.

'Come, my heart, come, my heart,
Dhin dhinak dhinak, dhin dhinak dhinak...
Ah, O Rāma, I shall set my parents' house on fire...!
Dim dimik dimik, dim dimik dimik...'

But who is this? Why, it is Chethru Gusāin! Gusāin is a devotee of Kabir. Ten or fifteen years ago, when the landlord demanded that he give false testimony, he refused. The angry landlord turned him out of his home, and he has lived as a renunciant ever since. Hand drum, shoulder-bag and tongs; matted locks and a long beard... Look! Gusāin begins to beat his khanjarī and dance alongside the performers.

'Dim dimik dimik, dim dimik dimik,
Ah, O Rāma, in my parents' house, a fire...'

For Chethru Gusāin, the song is entirely *nirguṇa*: an expression of the formless divine.

Ah! Tears shine in his sunken eyes. And the dance is over.

(Phanishwarnath Renu's reportage was published in the weekly *Vishvamitra* on 1 August 1945. This translation from Hindi into Maithili is dedicated to Phanishwarnath Renu. Acknowledgement: *Videha: Sadeha*, no. 11.)

I place this conception of *piyā desāntar*—the beloved gone to a distant land—before thoughtful readers and respectfully dedicate it to Mahākavi Vidyāpati, amid the present distress of Maithil migrants. Does the Sanskrit-Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura possess this anguish?

50. 'No One Could Understand Me' — Ghazal Poet Om Prakash Jhā

Abstract

In Bhādo the clouds gather heavily; no vidāgarī-tidāgarī is under way, yet the water-borne life stirs. The season is full; there is no call for elaborate dissection. But if a gust happens to blow towards a particular bahr—the metrical measure of the ghazal—there is no harm in that.

Keywords: Om Prakash Jhā; Maithili ghazal; separation; *bahr*; *sher*; poetic language; rhythm

In Bhādo the clouds hang heavy. There may be no *vidāgarī-tidāgarī*, yet the water-borne life stirs. Bhādo has arrived in force; there is no need to dissect everything.

Circling aimlessly is not a good thing. But if one happens to turn towards a particular *bahr*, that does no harm.

If a collection were made of Maithili ghazals written in proper *bahr*, Om Prakash would be among its finest practitioners.

'Blood kept flowing out of my heart.'
Love lives in the heart, and blood is flowing from it: someone must surely have driven a knife into it. Who could be so audacious? But the second line of the couplet says:

'Yet never did a tear of separation fall from my eyes.'
A history almost came into being—but why did it stop short?

'It would have become a story, had you understood the hint;
I was the one in your heart—if only you had said so once.'
Neither party, it seems, is entirely to blame.

The poet wishes his burning heart to go on burning:

'I cannot tell what fire kept burning in my heart;
My heart asked not for water but only for ghee.'

The ghazal writer has suffered a lover's wound but remains so close to the beloved that tears of separation would compromise that person. So he does not weep. He wants his heart to continue burning, and for ghee, never water, to be poured upon its fire.

People then suppose that his mind and heart are hard. He therefore writes:

'Tell me why nobody could ever understand me;
Everyone took my laughter for a great coldness.'

And there is this too:

'The world has struck me so often in love's false game;
No one saw my heart as it lay groaning.'

But whether people understand him or not—why should that matter so much? In another ghazal, written in *bahr-e-mutaqārib*, he declares:

'Who now has the stature to come and clash with me?
Whenever I have fought, I have always fought myself.'

Does that make the poet arrogant? Not quite. In *bahr-e-hazaj* he says:

'Let the world cut off Om's head now;
If a village can be saved by bowing, the *pāg* shines brighter.'

Are Maithili ghazal writers, then, still caught in the confines of love and separation, unable to take up new subjects? Not so. Listen to this *sher* in *bahr-e-salīm*:

'All the weapons will lie unused in the armoury;
The people driven by hunger have become missiles.'

And consider this ghazal for children. Children's poetry or ghazals generally evoke a voice of delight; where is such delight in the life of a child labourer? There remains hope, however:

'The darkness of sorrow spreads on every side;
It will pass, and I too shall grow.'

The same hope is found in another ghazal:

'I shall keep gathering shells along the seashore;
One day some shell will surely yield a pearl.'

When Om Prakash finds his pearl is another matter; Maithili literature has already found one in him. He has been recognised; he has been understood.

51. Munnāji: A Ghazal Poet and Writer of Bīhani Stories

Abstract

Mājh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī ('Marginalised in the Middle of the Courtyard') is the title of Munnāji's collection of rubāĭyāt and ghazals. Is this the influence of Kabir's paradoxical utterances, or simply the nature of the ghazal? Neither. It is a reality.

Keywords: Munnāji; ghazal; bīhani story; Mājh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī; rubā'ī; love; experiment in genre

Ghazal Poet Munnāji's *Mājh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī*

Mājh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī is the title of Munnāji's volume of rubā'iyāt and ghazals: pushed to the margin, and that too in the very middle of the courtyard! Is it Kabir's upside-down mode of speech, or the temperament of the ghazal? It is neither; it is a fact of life. Many people like Munnāji have been marginalised and lost sight of despite their talents. Yet the poet takes all the blame upon himself.

'Now I have been pushed aside in the middle of the courtyard;
My own manner of walking has led me astray.'

And that is why he begins to savour the strange pleasure of tears.

'The tears fall, yet somehow they seem sweet;
What a beautiful sorrow of love I have taken upon myself!'

He falls into a great ditch and holds himself responsible even for that:

'I learnt nothing from even the smallest stumble;
That is why I fell into so deep a pit.'

Has the ghazal poet forgotten the importance of love? No. Everyone needs love.

'People of every age need love;
They need goodwill and well-being until death.'

And if he had merely a mile or two to travel, perhaps it would be otherwise. But he has far to go, and so he needs love.

'Envy will carry you a mile or two;
To go farther, you need love.'

And this is true everywhere. A friend of mine once topped an examination and said, 'If I do not compete, I do not compete; but if I compete, I top it.' He was no ghazal poet. Had he been one, he might have written as Munnāji does:

'Let the clouds gather; that is no great matter,
But if they rain, let them come as the monsoon.'

He presents both a change of viewpoint and the idea of the glass being half full in this way:

'Raise your eyes and the world will seem empty;
Lower them and the whole world will appear.'

The poet values criticism as well as opposition.

'Keep your distance from those who merely take your side;
Do not think every word of an opponent bitter.'

Inflation has driven people to distraction. Consider the image of a swaying platform:

'Inflation dries up not just blood but bone;
People now seem like a watch-platform trembling in the air.'

Consider this paradox, too: the image is new, the feeling timeless.

'I lit a warming fire in the heat of summer;
From its extinguished embers, warm yourself one day.'

What kind of literary gathering is this, resembling the politics of sponsored letters published in certain magazines? Consider this rubāʿī:

'The heart grew heavy with shouts of distress;
The audience fled when fighting broke out;
The sponsor kept his ears attentively pricked,
And the organiser's caste affiliations stood exposed.'

If floods did not enter the Maithili ghazal, we would have to say its poets had become detached from society. But that is not the case.

'The river is still in full spate;
People stand on the embankment, watching one another.'

Migration out of Mithila has declined for the present. Outsiders have come to treat 'Bihari' as synonymous with labourer or worker. The poet writes of that too.

'Bihar's appearance seems to have changed today;
With workers in short supply, factory owners themselves look like Biharis.'

Munnāji's ghazals and rubāʿiyāt flow freely, like a bursting torrent. Such is the nature of a well-turned *sher*: it cannot fail to draw an 'āh' or a 'vāh' from its listeners. Seeing how the ghazal and rubāʿī are spreading in Maithili, one feels that, even as the genres extend their reach, the Maithili language is gaining still more and expanding with them.

52. Ashok the Poet, Ashok the Storyteller, and Ashok the Writer of Non-fictional Prose

Abstract

Although Ashok now calls himself "Storyteller Ashok" (that is the name on his Facebook profile), his first published book was a collection of poems, Chakravyūha, which appeared in January 1986. In November of that same year, Trikoṇ, a joint collection by Ashok, Shivshankar Shrinivas and Shailendra Anand, was published; each contributed five short stories. Ashok the poet, Ashok the storyteller, and Ashok the writer of non-fictional prose.

Keywords: Ashok; short-story writer; non-fictional prose; author; Mahābhārata; poetry

Abstract

Although Ashok now calls himself "Storyteller Ashok" (that is the name on his Facebook profile), his first published book was the poetry collection Chakravyūha, published in January 1986. In November of the same year, Trikoṇ, a joint collection by Ashok, Shivshankar Shrinivas and Shailendra Anand, appeared, containing five stories by each of the three. Ashok writes little, and poetry even less.

Editorial for the New Issue

Ashok the Poet, Ashok the Storyteller, and Ashok the Writer of Non-fictional Prose

Although Ashok now calls himself "Storyteller Ashok" (that is the name on his Facebook profile), his first published book was the poetry collection *Chakravyūha*, which appeared in January 1986. In November that year the joint collection *Trikoṇ*, containing five stories each by Ashok, Shivshankar Shrinivas and Shailendra Anand, was published.

Ashok writes sparingly, and produces even less poetry. Among mainstream authors, writing little has become a fashion. Premchand had written three hundred stories before bringing out a selection entitled *Merī Priya Kahāniyā̃* ("My Favourite Stories") in 1933. In that book he admits that, whether one wishes it or not, not everything an author writes can be good. He also observes that a reader who reads the entire output of one writer might not manage to read even five or six writers in a lifetime. That was why he came under pressure to select a few stories from his three hundred and offer them to readers as his favourites. In my view, too, an author ought to proclaim himself a storyteller only after writing three hundred stories. Premchand goes on to suggest there that folktales contain such things as flying horses, and that the literary short story is therefore of greater importance than the folktale. I differ from Premchand on this point and agree with Firaq Gorakhpuri. In his collection of *rubāīyāt*, *Rūp*, Firaq writes that "Hindu folksong" gives him something it transforms

into music both human and celestial, something even Ghalib, Iqbal and Chakbast could not give him. He offers this example:

"Father, I am leaving the home of my girlhood;
That threshold has become a mountain, and the courtyard a foreign land."

The Mahābhārata has by now become a folksong and a folk epic; the *Bhīl Mahābhārata* is an example. Some poems in Ashok's *Chakravyūha* draw upon the Mahābhārata and, in that sense, also upon folksong and folk narrative.

Thus, to my mind, there are three creative Ashoks: Ashok the poet, Ashok the storyteller, and Ashok the writer of non-fictional prose. Arvind Thakur calls his book *Roshnaik Lokpakṣ* non-fictional prose; I shall therefore use that expression as well for essays, treatises and criticism.

Gajendra Thakur

Ashok the Poet

"Father, I am leaving the home of my girlhood;
That threshold has become a mountain, and the courtyard a foreign land."

Ashok the Poet

First Phase: Ashok's *Chakravyūha* (A General Reading)

The Mahābhārata is a remarkable work. This *Jaya Saṃhitā* is a workshop for the short-story writer: the Mahābhārata tells stories, yet all those stories are in verse! An extremely condensed Maithili verse rendering of the Mahābhārata can be found in my *Tvañcāhañca—Gīt Prabandha*.

Then the fighting began again upon the thirteenth day,
As Arjuna pursued the Saṃśaptakas and the Trigartas away.
Yudhishthira learned then of the *chakravyūha* battle formation;
Seeing his anxious uncle, Abhimanyu offered an explanation:
"In the womb I heard my father describing it to my mother,
How to break through all its first six gates, one after another;
I remember every detail of that method of combat,
But not the account of fighting through its seventh gate;
Mother fell asleep, and that one gate alone remained."
Vyasa's image of learning in the womb
Is a symbol of the hero, not merely the literal sense of words.
Abhimanyu advanced, though no one understood,
Where the gate or point of entry stood, with Jayadratha on guard.
"Come, Uncle Bhima; here is the entrance, we shall go in here."
Abhimanyu struck Jayadratha with an arrow and entered,

But Jayadratha stood there barring Bhima and the other warriors.
At the second gate stood Drona, releasing his arrows;
Abhimanyu cut Drona's bow and pierced the array to advance.
At the third gate he showered arrows upon the astonished Karna,
And reached the fourth, where Ashwatthama stood.
A terrible battle broke out, yet he could not be stopped.
Abhimanyu's chariot advanced; Duryodhana grew anxious:
"Karna, what shall we do now? Defeat seems certain."
Karna said: "Let all seven great chariot warriors unite;
Together we can stop this boy; no one can do so alone."
All the warriors gathered, including Duryodhana's son Lakshmana;
By then Abhimanyu had reached the seventh gate.
Seeing the scene, Abhimanyu's charioteer said:
"These unrighteous men have joined forces. Shall I turn the chariot back?"
"I am Arjuna's son; I shall not abandon this battle. Watch;
Turn the chariot in a circle and behold the courage of Partha's son."
Then Lakshmana came directly before Abhimanyu;
An arrow severed Lakshmana's head. Drona declared:
"He is invincible, his armour impenetrable; strike his head!"
Then Abhimanyu's charioteer fell and his chariot broke apart.
He descended and fought on with sword, wheel and mace;
In mace combat with Dushasana's son, both fell to the ground.
Dushasana's son rose first and struck him on the head;
Among the seven chariot warriors fell Subhadra's son, Uttara's husband.
(Gajendra Thakur, *Tvañcāhañca—Gīt Prabandha*, 2009)

The opening poem of the collection *Chakravyūha*, also entitled "Chakravyūha," presents a day when neither Krishna nor Yudhishthira nor Arjuna is present. Today—the thirteenth day of the Mahābhārata war—the *chakravyūha* has been formed.

"I Shall Ask Something" describes the attempt to strip Draupadi.

In anger Duryodhana repeated his command:
"Dushasana, strip her! Draupadi is a slave."
Draupadi appealed to the worthy elders,
"Save my honour, I plead with you; I implore you."
Everyone in that assembly bowed their heads;
Krishnaa, Draupadi, had lost hope from every direction:
"Protector of devotees, in you alone rests my hope;
Somehow preserve my modesty—that is my prayer."
In a voice choked with emotion Draupadi called out;

Crying for help, she collapsed unconscious in the hall.
Dushasana began pulling at Draupadi's clothing;
The assembled people watched a miracle unfold,
For as long as Dushasana continued pulling,
Draupadi's garment went on growing without end.
(Gajendra Thakur, *Tvañcāhañca—Gīt Prabandha*, 2009)

Vyasa is satisfied with Krishna's role, but Ashok is not. Ashok's dissatisfaction arises from his sense that "in today's stripping of Draupadi / Krishna's role / kneels down / before Dushasana." Thus the Draupadi of his own relationship has been stripped naked. He wonders when there will be a Vetala carrying his own corpse on his back, and when a Vikramaditya will appear. The poem "From Soviet Russia" evokes a narrative that was served up to Ashok's generation: the Soviet Union was praised and America was disparaged, even while those who did the praising sent their own children to America for their education. I remember a friend who went to Darbhanga to take an examination. After wandering about the university area, he returned saying that there could be no better city in all Bihar than Darbhanga. Ashok does something similar in this poem. He dislikes people who vote four times in a year and then snore soundly after casting their ballots, but he fails to see the social equations that take shape around these repeated elections. Nor can he recognise the rising wave of those catalytic forces of social change produced by such equations. "The Song That Was Never Written" and "What Shall I Tell You?" concern the suffering inherent in the poet's vocation. "People Do Nothing" takes up human inertia, while "I Had Promised You" explores human self-interest. "Sanchikāsta" is built around the vocabulary of office files. The image in "Inscription" is beautiful. Addressing a tyrant, the poet asks whether the tyrant's thirst for blood should be engraved and securely preserved upon a stone inscription. But this tyrant is God: the poet asks him to accept death and then remarks ironically that he will certainly be reborn. The conception of a universe with more than three dimensions and Stephen Hawking's *A Brief History of Time* directly threaten the existence of God, for they also bring the possibility of God's death into view: the existence of the world's controller is in jeopardy. Francis Fukuyama, who announced the end of history when communist rule collapsed, subsequently retreated from the claim. After communist government fell and the Berlin Wall came down, Fukuyama declared that history generated by the conflicts among ideologies had ended and that only ideologies beneficial to humanity would now advance. Some time later, however, he revised his position, saying that many rival ideologies still survived within societies and among nationalities. Against the background of the death of God and the end of history, "Inscription" is important. If we wish to find a relationship between the poet's heart and nature in "Again Some

Lightning Flashed," we can—for example, in the image "it rained in the courtyard plastered with cow-dung." "Whom Do You Want?" asks whether you want words or meaning: words are chaff or husks, and meaning is grain. The poet will supply whichever you choose. In "Silence Does Not Become You," he complains: silence was endured for the sake of the stomach, yet the stomach still remains unfilled. He remembers the waterside near his village; and when his superior officer rebukes him, in the next poem, "I Shall Certainly Write a Letter Today," the village returns to his mind, and he wishes to abandon everything and go home. "Alone" speaks of seeing tears in the mirror of time, the outcry of solitude after separation. In "Before Creation," every line appears unfamiliar to the poet, who wonders how so much of his life has passed. "Zero" is a poem about a failure to meet; it is not even a poem about travelling on parallel paths. In "The Bell of the Mind," remembrance brings a coolness like sandalwood, while forgetfulness brings a hissing serpent. The poet has brought the images of sandalwood and snake from Sanskrit *subhāṣitas* into Maithili, but in a somewhat altered form. The roots of the sandalwood tree are parasitic: they take water and minerals by breaking into the roots of another tree. The banyan and the peepal are not parasitic trees, yet when young they need other trees for support, like props to help them stand. Little by little their roots so engulf the supporting trees that those trees wither, deprived of water and sunlight. Does this complicate our understanding of the image "even a snake wrapped around a cool sandalwood tree is not without venom"? Ashok, however, is careful: he confines himself to the sandalwood's coolness. Am I needlessly applying Jacques Derrida's deconstructive method to this criticism? The image of the wagging tail of the "Cringing Dog" recalls a Sanskrit *subhāṣita*: "The endeavour of a crow, the concentration of a heron, the sleep of a dog, eating little and living away from home—these are the five qualities of a student." Here "the sleep of a dog" means waking at the slightest sound. Yet on the four-lane road near my village thousands of people have died in accidents, and almost as many dogs have died while asleep upon the road. People say dogs sleep very heavily! Where, then, is the proverbial light sleep of the dog? Have we robbed them of their habitat? Are the vehicles moving so fast that a dog cannot hear them in time to become alert? Has this Sanskrit *subhāṣita* been rendered false by humanity's interference with the environment? With Derrida I have wandered unnecessarily into environmental discourse; Ashok has simply used the image of a frightened dog wagging its tail. "An Unframed Picture" again returns to his solitude. In "Give Me Some Name," he feels that his existence disappears before the other's immense form. "A Song of the Sad Dawn" is a song of pain, pain extending from the heart through the body. In "How Long?" the poet seeks a fair in which to lose himself, continually plastering the clay of hope upon a vessel of coloured dreams. But for how long? "One Point: Three

Images" offers three images: the fulfilment of a desire; bloodshot eyes; and falling without attempting to save oneself. In "The Three Letters of Love," the first image is of words written by reading the language of her eyes: however forcefully he writes them out, the lines come forth like pearls. In the second he sees her reflection in his mind's mirror, a reflection he wishes to swallow, grind and chew until he is bloodied. In the third he is afraid even to approach her. Here, then, are love's three letters, beyond its proverbial two-and-a-half. "One Night" evokes the coolness of night and its pleasing sensations—but the daytime sun? Day—no, no. "Evening" comes shamelessly each day, and the poet tells it to go away or he will increase the light. "A New Scene" sings of the new year: while striving to become a hero rather than a villain, one must not end up as an extra; then the old apprehension and despair recur. "A Pearl with the Fragrance of a Shell" invokes Gandhi's tolerance and non-cooperation movement within a procession of ideals. One can laugh heartily not upon winning but upon losing! A pearl can form from a tear that has fallen and hardened. Next come "Five Unnecessary Poems." The first concerns Krishna's birthday, celebrated every year at Janmashtami, but this time Krishna has forgotten his flute and arrived with a violin. The poet evidently considers the violin a foreign instrument: in terms of Hindustani music that is true, but Carnatic music incorporated this foreign violin two hundred years ago. The second unnecessary poem concerns the dance floor, where once again his foot slips. The third concerns a rickshaw-puller; only when the front wheel is jerked askew does he understand the world. The fourth concerns relationships accumulated over a lifetime for the sake of living—but! The fifth concerns the dark tongue of destruction. The last poem in *Chakravyūha* is "Two Drops of Tears": storm and tempest, yet none greater than the tempest of the heart. There is no beloved dark one; there is only the expectation of death. "And I die!" The broken house of earth and tiles is washed away, together with the body made of clay.

Second Phase: Ashok after *Chakravyūha* (A General Reading)

In "Once Again," the little son's sorrow is accompanied by a mass of dark clouds and the urge to write poetry; we see that the atmosphere for Ashok's poetry forms when there is sadness. "Teeth" refers to the advice given to a bride that she must not open her mouth in her husband's family. In "Now...," he observes changes in proverbs as the use of mud, wood and bamboo declines and that of cement, sand, stone chips, iron and marble increases. "Brahmottar" examines the pain caused by the acquisition of trees, houses and fields in the name of development. Once land was taken from cultivators and allotted as *brahmottar* grants; today it is taken from ordinary people and distributed among new Brahmins. Yet Nandigram has challenged the global village. In "Moustache," he explains the importance of weapons while identifying the elder's moustache as an obstacle to

greatness; alternatively, he advises people to work and earn so that their moustache is not stained. At the "Liberation Ceremony," a dove, the emblem of peace, is released; passing from one politician's hand to another, it is distressed by its unfulfilled hope for freedom—"My India is great." In "Do Something Now, Āchārya!" the teacher merely worries but does not listen to his disciple. In "When He Dies of Thirst," the person whose silence had displeased the poet now sets about silencing the poet himself. "Do Not Labour under This Illusion" warns the politician Mishra. In "Context: An Election Year," democracy is Draupadi in the poem "Election," whereas "Vote" depicts deception and intrigue committed to win votes. "Politics Now Smells" exposes the grotesque face of politics. "Toofan Ali Said" discusses the manufacture of counterfeit Hindu and Muslim identities. In "The Clever Man," the character Kakka seeks cracks in every household like the roots of a banyan or a peepal. In "Poetry Betrays Humanity," the poet defines not only what poetry is but also what it is not: "Poetry is not the *bel* leaf offered by worshippers of the phallus." In "Poison," he searches for a venomous serpent. "Eating and Bathing" speaks of the old belief that few people had seen a man eating or a woman bathing—but what of the present? In "The Genie," the genie of one's own making has stopped speaking. "What Happened?" concerns a person reduced to an idol. In "Maithili in the Eighth Schedule," now that a cherished ambition has been fulfilled, the poet cannot decide whether to become a Vaishnava, play *pachīsī*, or bathe in the Ganges, as though nothing remains to be done. Whether it is Maithili's entry into the Sahitya Akademi or its inclusion in the Eighth Schedule, both developments have increased and strengthened mainstream rigidity. Beyond the purchase of certain mainstream hardbound books by libraries and the mainstream's unproductive seminars, Maithili has gained nothing from this, while the parallel current of Maithili literature must now work harder to contend with these developments. "The Season Is Changing" discusses rising atmospheric temperatures, yet despite considerable effort the poet cannot perceive the changing seasons, mounting heat and flying egrets. In "Mahaprakash Has Gone," Sukant Som brings news of Mahaprakash's death, and the poet finds only the consolation that he will have work to do in the winter.

What precedes is a general reading of Ashok's poetry.

A Critique of Ashok's Poetry in the Light of Eastern and Western Theories (for the theories themselves, see my *Maithili Samīkṣāśāstra*, available from Videha Books at www.videha.co.in)

An Examination from Marxist, Historical, Structuralist, Magical-Realist, Postmodern, Feminist and Deconstructionist Perspectives, Together with the Perspective of Indian Aesthetics

Of Ashok's poems in *Chakravyūha* and those written after *Chakravyūha*, not one poem in the former will disappoint you; many of the later poems, however, will seem dull, with the exception of "When He Dies of Thirst."

From a structuralist standpoint, "Chakravyūha" and "I Shall Ask Something" seem to be based upon a universal Mahābhārata narrative: only the place, time and characters have changed.

There is a depiction of Draupadi's disrobing. Vyasa is satisfied with Krishna's role, but Ashok is not. The reason for Ashok's dissatisfaction is his impression that "in today's stripping of Draupadi / Krishna's role / kneels down / before Dushasana." Thus the Draupadi belonging to his own relationship has been stripped naked. He asks when there will be a Vetala carrying his own corpse on his back, and when a Vikramaditya will arrive.

Leaving structuralism aside for a moment, let us turn to a historical analysis. "From Soviet Russia" is a poem about a narrative within which Soviet authoritarianism lay concealed—a system that has now collapsed.

From a Marxist perspective, "The Song That Was Never Written," "What Shall I Tell You?," "People Do Nothing" and "I Had Promised You" show poetic work reaching beyond the merely poetic. These poems combine affirmation and its denial, old and new, development and death. If they had detached themselves from their circumstances and indulged merely in praise and admiration, they would have been inferior from a Marxist standpoint—as are so many of the barren mainstream Maithili songs celebrating Mithila's imagined splendour. Instead, the poet has made them part of a dynamic process.

Let us now look at "Sanchikāsta," "Whom Do You Want?," "Silence Does Not Become You" and "I Shall Certainly Write a Letter Today" from a deconstructionist perspective. A deconstructionist would say that the structuralist's poles take on a philosophical form. The poet's statements themselves cast doubt upon whether his own polarisation is permanent or fleeting. A deprived class may migrate from the village and throw off its social stigma; the powerful class, by contrast, misses the prestige it enjoyed in the village, as we see in "Sanchikāsta." In "I Shall Certainly Write a Letter Today," the sight of the officer's angry red eyes likewise makes the poet wish to return to his village. "Whom Do You Want?" announces the

end of ideals and morality: words, whether truth or falsehood, and meanings are available in abundance, and everything is for sale with a single signature; but ideals and morality are out of stock and cannot be sold. All this questions the permanence or transience of the poet's polarities.

"Inscription" uses a paradox: people record their glory on stone inscriptions, but the poet wants to inscribe upon the tyrant's own stone the record of his thirst for blood! Let us return to the historicity of the poem. Imagine a magical-realist literary work read in a future age: a character living in that work might assign this poem a third, quite different meaning. The poet's own existence would then disappear, and the science of words would begin its play. For a character in magical-realist literature who lives in the future, the poem will possess another meaning altogether, even as that character searches for the emotion of the poet's verse. A little further on, we realise it is about God: the poet asks God to pack up his belongings and wonders whether he should announce God's death. This was the meaning of Nietzsche's proclamation that God is dead: God was an idea, a mode of thought, which the scientific thinking following the Enlightenment in the West destroyed. In India, Pūrva Mīmāṃsā and Sāṃkhya had already rejected the idea of God. Both, however, are *āstika* philosophical systems: they recognise the authority of the Vedas while not acknowledging God. Thus, whether he intends it or not, Ashok differs at many points from Mithila's mainstream tradition derived from the *Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* and approaches its parallel tradition. Language must have existed before the *Ṛgveda*, the oldest surviving work of Vedic Sanskrit. Much oral literature—*gāthās*, *nārāśaṃsīs*, divine tales and narratives—would have been composed in it. For the singers of these narrative songs, the *Ṛgveda* uses the terms *gāthin*, *gātuvid* and *gāthapati*. *Gāthā* and *nārāśaṃsī* existed in parallel from Vedic times. Vishvamitra was a *gāthin*, a son of Gathin and a seer of the Gāyatrī. Did Vedic Sanskrit emerge from Prakrit, or Prakrit from Vedic Sanskrit? The *nārāśaṃsī* narratives in the Vedas show that the two continued alongside one another for a very long time; this parallel tradition influenced both. Consider the *Ṛgveda*: what does its use of *dūlabha* for *durlabha* (4.9.8) establish? What does *paścā* for *paścāt* in the *Atharvaveda* (10.4.10) establish? And what does *pratisaṃhāya* for *pratisaṃdhāya* in the *Gopatha Brāhmaṇa* (2.4) establish? Those who were Aryans came to Mithila from western India. Certain portions of the Vedas existed before their arrival, which is why many words and pronunciations found in Maithili occur in Vedic Sanskrit but not in Classical Sanskrit. Avidyā, the doctrine of karma, the cycle of birth and rebirth, and liberation were received by the Aryans from non-Aryans. That is why the Upanishads teach the way to liberation, not the way to heaven. How does one achieve liberation? Through sacrifice? No:

through knowledge, reflection, contemplation and meditative absorption. Under King Janaka's patronage, Yājñavalkya composed the *Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad* in the non-Aryan region of Tirhut. Commenting upon the fifty-seventh sūtra of the *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, Vācaspati Miśra asks whether we can say that just as unconscious milk nourishes a calf, unconscious nature gives a living being the knowledge of liberation through its activity. God is complete within himself: what purpose would creation serve for him? If he created the world for living beings, those beings would become bound only after creation; before creation there could be no question of bondage. Why, then, would compassion towards them arise? Creation is brought about by *prakṛti*, and living beings attain *apavarga*, release, through their own effort. Dissolution, too, comes through discriminative understanding. Vācaspati's account is therefore non-theistic, not theistic. If God participates in the operation of nature, it becomes a conscious process governed by a purpose; and God, having no need, can have no such purpose. Gautama of Mithila, the author of the *Nyāyasūtra*, speaks of attaining the highest good through knowledge of the sixteen categories, but nowhere among them does he say that liberation can be obtained through God. The *Vaiśeṣikasūtra* holds that the Vedas were composed by learned people, not by God. Kumārila Bhaṭṭa says that no reliable discourse about God before creation is possible. In "Inscription" Ashok takes a step further: he knows that God, too, will be reborn after death. In "Two Drops of Tears," likewise, there is no dark beloved; there is only the anticipation of death: "And I die!" Magical realism reappears; the poet sees himself being carried away in the waters.

The rhythm of "Alone" is remarkable. Read "Again Some Lightning Flashed," "The Bell of the Mind," "Give Me Some Name" and "A Song of the Sad Dawn" in the light of *dhvani* theory. Ashok presents meaning and symbol together. Nyāya philosophy opposed *dhvani* theory, but Ashok nonetheless offers a forceful structure of suggestion. His poems, filled with these symbols, advance in a well-organised manner. Read them from a formalist standpoint: the poet makes effective use of the unfamiliar aspects of language, thereby generating poetic quality. The abundance of opposed words, the unfamiliar nature of their combinations, and a language rich in figures of sound make the poems distinctive. Their manner of combination gives them formalist excellence. Read them also in the light of *sphoṭa*: the transmission of meaning occurs not merely through isolated words but through the integrated burst of signification.

Consider "One Night," "Evening," "A New Scene," "A Pearl with the Fragrance of a Shell," "Five Unnecessary Poems," "How Long?," "Before Creation," "The Cringing Dog," "An Unframed Picture," "One Point: Three Images" and "The Three Letters of Love" from an existentialist

perspective. The poet assumes responsibility for his own condition, his solitary life and his anxieties. From the standpoint of *aucitya*—propriety or aptness—the descriptions are justified by the requirements of the poems.

Read "Zero" through deconstruction. Mathematics makes it zero; but how shall one answer the exhaustion that follows? The poem then becomes caught in its own net: much will be left unsaid, and yet very much will remain to be said.

Second Phase: Ashok after *Chakravyūha*

The poems of the second phase call for a sociological method of criticism. "Once Again," "Now...," "Brahmottar," "Moustache," "Liberation Ceremony," "Do Something Now, Āchārya!," "Do Not Labour under This Illusion," "Context: An Election Year," "Vote," "Politics Now Smells," "Toofan Ali Said," "The Clever Man," "Poetry Betrays Humanity," "Poison," "The Genie," "What Happened?" and "The Season Is Changing" all deal with one problem or another.

"When He Dies of Thirst" is a sequel to "Silence Does Not Become You" in *Chakravyūha*. "The Season Is Changing" comments on the environment, while "Vote" comments on politics. But have we not read a great deal more prose dealing with these very subjects? Is that why the poems now seem ordinary?

"Maithili in the Eighth Schedule" resembles Faiz's anguished response to the formation of Pakistan—"This is not the dawn we were promised"—only in its suggested meaning; its literal meaning is ironic.

"Once Again" and "Mahaprakash Has Gone" are grounded in individual psychology.

"Teeth" and "Eating and Bathing" call for a feminist reading. From a sociological standpoint, they are poems opposing social customs. The theories concerning women—even literary theories—framed by men within a male-centred society cannot be regarded as appropriate for women. In any case, both poems are weak treatments of their subjects.

Ashok's poems may also be read through the theory of *alaṃkāra*, or figures of speech. Kabir has taught us the art of indirect simile, metaphor and the contradiction of resemblance. A reading through *rasa* theory is possible as well. Ashok develops *anubhāvas*—expressive responses or effects—from *vibhāvas*, the determinants of emotion. He uses this procedure at several points, especially in *Chakravyūha*. But after *Chakravyūha*, the poet disappoints us here as well.

The Ashok who had carried poetry forward even to the rebirth that followed God's death came to a halt after *Chakravyūha*. Did the

mainstream's pseudo-criticism kill Ashok the poet? Yet the poet Ashok will be reborn, and soon. "When He Dies of Thirst," the sequel to "Silence Does Not Become You" from *Chakravyūha*, has already planted the seed of that rebirth.

Gajendra Thakur

Ashok the Storyteller

"Father, I am leaving the home of my girlhood;
That threshold has become a mountain, and the courtyard a foreign land."

Ashok the Storyteller

Trikoṇ (Short-Story Collection, 1986)

Dedicated to the late Dr Braj Kishore Verma "Manipadma," *Trikoṇ* contains five stories each by Ashok, Shivshankar Shrinivas and Shailendra Anand.

Ashok's five are "Haḍḍī" ("The Bone"), "Hairpin," "Antim Shah" ("The Final Check"), "Ekaṭā Muskurāit Āṅkhi" ("A Smiling Eye") and "Khauñjh" ("Irritation").

"The Bone": Jageshar, his wife Seema, daughter Gudiya and son Pappu are the characters. Jageshar is delayed at the office; his rented accommodation is far from work, while lodgings nearby are expensive. A suicide has taken place next door, apparently because the lawyer's daughter-in-law could not endure harassment over dowry. Everyone in the locality is afraid. Jageshar feels as though a bone is stuck in his throat, hence the title "The Bone." From its naming to its execution, the entire story is ordinary.

"Hairpin": The characters are Chander and Urmila, separated for the first time since their marriage. Urmila went to the village five days earlier. Chander picks up a magazine: pictures of women that formerly held no attraction now draw his attention. The milkmaid arrives. Previously he had seen only the milk, but today he notices the milkmaid as well. Why had he never looked at her before? She goes into the other room to put the milk away, and Chander closes the door. She is frightened of him, but he presses two hundred rupees upon her. She forgets everything; he imagines that she will leave the house and not return for several days because she must go to the village. Chander begins to be swept up in a storm, to become soaked in rain—the storyteller uses both expressions as metaphors for intercourse. Then the narrator says that Chander has a fever today and will not go to work; we can already see that the tale is about to turn into a paradox. Chander reads letters. He finds one that Ramanand wrote to Urmila two months earlier and becomes angry: is Ramanand her lover? Was her love for him a lie? The next morning Urmila arrives with

Ramanand. Chander is furious, but Urmila explains, in the manner of a film, that Ramanand is her paternal aunt's son. He found a job in Calcutta two months before the wedding and could not attend, so they had never met. Chander's suspicion disappears—but now it is Urmila's turn. In the next room she finds a hairpin. She never wears hairpins; whose can it be? She asks Chander. This hairpin gives the story its title, and it is almost screaming in Urmila's hand. The story ends, but I, as a reader, feel cheated. My attention has been diverted to the way the milkmaid seems to have been assigned a price of two hundred rupees, making it difficult to attend to the intended point. The writer wants to draw our attention to the moral character of men and women, especially male-centred judgements and hypocrisy, but he fails to do so.

"The Final Check": Bisheshar, his wife, son Kusheshar and daughter-in-law Phuleshari are the principal characters. Kusheshar has gone to Patna with Ramrachana and drives a rickshaw there. Fifteen years earlier, Bisheshar borrowed two hundred rupees from Phool Babu for the marriage of his daughter Dhanmanti. Kusheshar was a small boy then; at Sukrati he had thrown a wrestler from Dharampur to the ground. The landowner patted his back, and although the boy played beautifully and was placed upon a buffalo, he never liked being restrained. Kusheshar now returns from Patna. No longer does he drive a hired rickshaw: he owns one and belongs to a union. Phool Babu is playing chess. He has already received interest exceeding twice the principal, but keeps adding more. He does not intend to return the bond, yet is forced to do so. Times have changed; this story goes far beyond Premchand's Hindi "Savā Ser Gehū" ("A Seer and a Quarter of Wheat"). At the same time, Mishraji gives Phool Babu the "final check" on the chessboard and defeats him. Phuleshari will no longer have to go and work in the mansion.

"A Smiling Eye": The protagonist remembers a master who once tutored him. The master taught him to live as though he were performing a role. The departure of the living troubles the protagonist more than people's deaths, but through the art of acting he conceals this pain. The master searches out his flute once more, cleans it and plays for his pupil. Hearing the mournful strain, the protagonist falls asleep, forgetting the pain of his grief. Many other nostalgic memories return to him.

"Irritation": Smoke rises from an open fire. Ramnarayan throws down an eight-anna coin and orders a *pān*. Ravishekhar has come from the village with a bag to attend to some work at the Board office. Something has happened between Ramnarayan and his wife Sudhira. He sets out with Ravishekhar for their lodging, but feels as though a heavy wooden log were tied to his feet. They discuss the decline of drama in the village, the notion that supplementary earnings are disreputable, and even tea without

milk when no milk is available. Then the writer tries to pull the story together. There is only one mosquito net; they will borrow money from Chaudharyji to buy another. But Sudhira has saved fifty rupees and will give it for the net. The ending is happy, and just then electricity returns. Ramnarayan hears the fan in Ravishekhar's room; even without a mosquito net, the mosquitoes will no longer trouble him.

Within this collection of still-immature stories, "A Smiling Eye" gives some grounds for confidence about the future.

Ohi Rātik Bhor (Short-Story Collection, 1991)

Dedicated to the late Sushil Jha, *Ohi Rātik Bhor* contains fifteen Ashok stories. Kulanand Mishra contributes the prefatory "In Passing," but it obstructs the reading of the stories. Kula Babu writes, for example, that "limitations gradually fell away—Ashokji's story of 1977, 'Baukā Chup Chhal' ('Bauka Was Silent'), and his story of 1989, 'Sarisabak Sāg' ('Mustard Greens'), can be read and understood together." Yet such a comparison actually makes "Bauka Was Silent" stand far above "Mustard Greens." In the psychology of the man and woman—in both stories a husband and wife—both spouses in "Bauka Was Silent" reveal the immensity of their inner selves, whereas the spouses in "Mustard Greens" behave like figures in an ordinary Hindi television serial. The stories in this collection are as follows.

"Before the Interval": Sameer leaves his examination unfinished and his father is stunned. The bell rings at the examination centre; it is time for the examination to begin, but Sameer has abandoned it because he has developed a fever. The plot had promise, but the writer fails to reach the central issue until half the story has gone by and makes an unsuccessful attempt to rescue the story in the final paragraph.

"Bauka Was Silent": Because the doctor's wife has gone to the village, the moonlight is pouring down around him. The description becomes rather protracted. The central plot begins when Bauka is bitten by a snake, and the doctor sets off to see him. The real story lies there. Though Bauka understands everything, he remains silent. He was a master at cutting earth, but illness overcame him. His wife Radhiya arrives late, wearing perfume; Bauka does not ask who put the scent upon her or where. Radhiya says that if he is angry he may beat her, but Bauka merely smooths her hair. Even when his sister-in-law abuses Radhiya, Bauka says nothing. His death comes not from disease but from the snakebite. Then comes Radhiya's lament. After such beautiful psychological analysis, the author did not need to conclude by making the sight of Radhiya remind the doctor of another pillow. Both opening and ending weaken the story, and

a beautiful tale is ruined. This is a striking example of the effects of the mainstream's spurious criticism.

"Another Brahma": A *brahmabhoj*, the ritual feast after a death. Someone cheats Chhitan out of his money, but people say that he is lying because he is afraid of paying for the feast. Chhitan will therefore raise money against his land and hold the feast.

"The Mind Hung in Prison": The chief characters are the hot-tempered Asit, his even-tempered friend Kishore, and Asit's sister Meena. Asit is in prison and will be released only after the Emergency, according to a letter from his father. Meena must be married off in Asit's absence. A flashback follows: Meena and Kishore; Meena is lively and likes breaking the little *ṭikulā* ornaments. One day she begins calling Kishore "brother," which displeases him. Only a few days remain before her marriage. The story ends.

"A Crossroads Means Chandinath": First a crossroads is described, then Chandinath, who frequents it. Chandinath's mother tells tales of good and ill fortune, makes hearths and household implements, and provides for their meagre food. His wife is beginning to go outdoors a little, but they have no children. During the Emergency, Chandinath was once jailed in a ticket inspection case. Mischievous boys spread a rumour that he had been sterilised, and when his wife asked about it, he even beat her. He needs a child to silence the village gossip, but none has yet arrived. He will now stand for village headman. The story ends.

"He Became a Human Being": Here are the seeds of the writer whom you now call "Storyteller Ashok." This is the story of becoming an ordinary, earning-and-spending person—which is also the story of life coming to an end, of abandoning my companionship. "I tried hard to save you from becoming merely a human being, but you preferred completeness. I had kept a little emptiness in you so that your writing and thinking might continue to flow. Neelu entered your life but became someone else's, because she hungered for a man, and at that time you could not satisfy that human hunger. There was something incomplete in you; that is why Meenu, your imagined beloved, was born. But I know there was no difference between them. Meenu was life itself; she could never have become anything else." There is an episode from the hostel: affection for a younger student, almost like a little brother, because you had none. People alleged an illicit relationship; you decided the laugh forcibly produced by the accusation was the product of an unhealthy mind, yet you could never declare the allegation false. "I know that laughter was constructing a word for you, but to others it carried only one meaning; at the price of that meaning your rights were mortgaged there, and a wall of silence rose between you. When talking and the clamour stop, thought begins to

move. Today you have wife, home and money, everything, but you have grown weak. You say Neelu is dead, yet you too are dead now. I alone can see it, for I am not dead."

"The Third Question": A very ordinary story. Rampravesh Chaudhary retires and returns to his village. His unemployed son Krishnakant runs away to Calcutta and earns a great deal. He spends generously on his sister's marriage; Rampravesh begins buying land in instalments and eating meat prepared from slaughtered animals. Krishnakant sends money but never visits the village, not even for his sister's wedding. When he finally comes, a CBI arrest warrant follows him: he has been manufacturing counterfeit medicines.

"The Timid One": Another mediocre story. Subhash and Manju quarrel over a grafted mango tree and its young fruit. Manju is to be married that year. Suddenly Subhash gathers her into his arms and takes her behind a tree, but Tejua and Shankar arrive and blows with sticks follow. A village council orders Subhash expelled, and he runs away. Ten years later he returns. His mother is dead; he has a nephew. His elder brother tells him that Manju later spoke in his defence, said she would marry him and that people searched for Subhash in vain. Manju's marriage fell through. You will already have guessed that the sister-in-law is Manju herself—and so it is.

"The Dancer": Here Ashok begins, at last, to find his voice. In Nainital, Anand, the protagonist, meets Rajni Sharma, formerly his fellow student at a college in Sitamarhi. Dowry considerations have forced her into marriage with an impotent man twice her age. They meet at a Nainital hotel. Also present is Sohan Mandal of the Purnia region, once a member of Dukhi Das's Bidapat dance troupe. Dukhi Das has died; the Bidapat dance itself is dying, and Sohan has come to Nainital. The story narrowly escapes mediocrity. In its final eight lines the writer tries to rescue it, and succeeds. Sohan and Rajni marry; he learns dance, and the two visit the protagonist in Patna.

"Mirza Sahib": The tenth story in the collection. The writer cannot bring it under control. I am reminded of Sushil's stories, particularly "Masjid" and others in *Asmitā* (a collection of short-short stories available in the Videha archive): excellent stories, carefully unfurled, without haste. "Mirza Sahib," by contrast, is mediocre despite its promising plot. Mirza Sahib's wife comes from a nawab family. Her mother died, and her father raised her. Her maternal uncle, aunt and the rest of that family are in Pakistan; she speaks of them frequently, much to Mirza Sahib's displeasure. After her father dies, Pakistan virtually becomes her parental home. She travels there with their son Salim for a wedding. Meanwhile war breaks out between India and Pakistan, in which her sister's husband is killed. In anger she

writes to Mirza Sahib against India. Their correspondence begins again after Salim qualifies as a doctor there. When the wife returns with Salim, Mirza Sahib has died in the Bombay riots. It is plot upon plot. The beginning raised hopes; I even began to analyse a dream by Freud's method, but the promise remained unfulfilled.

"Concern": Suresh, a friend adept at disguise, is denied justice after Chandranath and his associates gang-rape his wife. Chandranath, the rapist and a political leader standing in a parliamentary election, is murdered by Suresh. The story resembles a pale, yellowed copy of Amitabh Bachchan's film *Aakhree Raasta*. Almost everything is mediocre, although the writer recovers something in the final eight lines. Suresh's son Paresh now lives with the protagonist. He too is a born mimic and a master of disguise, but for reasons no one knows he remembers Chandranath particularly well, imitating his politician's manner to perfection.

"The Day the Sun Did Not Rise": The story of Jogiya and the society around him; it is also the story of Bauasin. Jogiya's father is dead and his mother has entered into a relationship in another neighbourhood. An uncle and aunt live in the courtyard, while Jogiya stays with a landowner. In that household Bauasin is blamed for being barren and is being tormented to death; the younger landowner intends to marry again. She had begged Jogiya to free her. Jogiya's mother obtained freedom, but Bauasin did not. The younger landowner will not take Bauasin to a doctor; since she has no child, it is simply assumed that the fault lies with her—or with some other supposed defect. The story brings together the manners of two communities and the issue of dowry. Yet after surveying the vast world of Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdev Mandal, Ramvilas Sahu, Ramanand Mandal, Santosh Kumar Rai "Batohi," Kapileshwar Raut, Sandeep Kumar Safi, Umesh Paswan, Umesh Mandal, Kishan Karigar, Ram Chandra Rai, Laldev Mahto and Nand Vilas Rai, all this seems insipid.

"Mustard Greens": Another mediocre story. When the protagonist's wife first came to his home, she was afraid; now she is not. A vegetable seller relates his sorrows to her in order to overcharge her, and cheats her. The protagonist becomes jealous, disliking his wife's smiling conversations with the vendor. She replies that when she speaks pleasantly, he weighs the vegetables correctly and sells them cheaply as well!

"The Earth Is Round": Manoj, Sudhakant and Tapan are in Moscow for training. There is casual conversation; after drinking they fall asleep in a park. Ashok wants a startling ending and introduces an elderly woman who speaks Russian and lays her hand on Tapan's head. Her affection makes him think of his mother, as though she had come in disguise. But the conclusion makes little impact.

"The Dawn of That Night": The title story. Two friends: Hira, a Brahmin who runs a *pān* shop, and Pulkit, an Amat who runs a tea stall. In an election for village headman, Subodh Mishra, a Brahmin, stands against Sattan Mandal of Raima, who belongs to Pulkit's caste. Perhaps, in Raima, the title Mandal is used by Amats. The election causes a quarrel between the friends. Only after all their money is exhausted on litigation do they come to their senses. Attempting another dramatic ending, the author brings Pulkit to Hira like a shadow at eleven at night. Hira says, in effect, "If you want to strike me, strike again," but the two embrace.

Mātbar (Short-Story Collection, 2001)

Dedicated to "all the participants in *Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray* who listened to stories and deliberated upon them," *Mātbar* contains eighteen stories by Ashok. It opens with "Ekaś Ekaīs," by Mohan Bhardwaj, a mainstream critic whose writing amounts largely to idle chatter. Ashok's observation of society astonishes him—as perhaps it ought to astonish mainstream people: an examination of both the forward and backward communities! Ashok does present both sides, but balancing opposing positions is the task of an essay. It is wrong for a storyteller to accept such pressure. Bhardwaj then adorns Ashok's writing with what he calls the "Maithil weave," of which he identifies two marks: becoming a teller of yarns and giving extended descriptions of reality. In the next paragraph he declares the second not merely a condition for a Maithil story but for a *Maithili* story. On that reasoning, hardly anything in the world could be non-Maithil! In my village such chatter masquerading as criticism is called *bakathothī*, and is not held in esteem. He goes on to describe Ashok as a believer in development and a realist; in elaborating, he even calls caste-based and religious mentalities "realistic mentalities." Nowadays such thinking is called "woke" in the West, where it too is not regarded favourably. Before writers of the parallel current began attending *Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray*, this kind of criticism was the fashion, and stories were discussed there in much the same way.

Let us now consider the stories in *Mātbar*.

"Mātbar": The title story of *Ohi Rātik Bhor* was the last in that collection; "Mātbar" is the first story in the collection of that name. Maharajji is the chief networker—the kind of person nowadays said to provide a single-window service. "He," the protagonist, goes to Maharajji to arrange a posting where there is money to be made. His current officer is a scoundrel who gives him work with no opportunity to earn even a little unofficial income; perhaps Maharajji can exert pressure on him. Everyone gathers at Maharajji's place, eating, drinking and chatting. The author details two or three accompaniments to the liquor, including boiled eggs. But what happened to the real errand "he" came to accomplish? On his way home he

narrowly escapes a beating; perhaps the thieves recognise him. His wife and son are angry with him too. The story ends. It is exceedingly ordinary.

"Signature": The story of an IAS officer, beginning with a description of his fingers and ending with his thumb. Corruption, moral depravity and bureaucratic red tape are described in the manner of reportage. At last his thumb ceases to function. He will go to America for treatment—but how can he obtain a passport without a signature? Hence the title.

"The Room": A story about a minister, written as reportage. The author carries it forward in the style of the reportage about the IAS officer in "Signature." An excellent story.

"Ease and Unease": Ashok the storyteller is beginning to come into his own. Kameshar has become an officer, moved to town, takes tablets to sleep and observes restrictions in his diet. Success exacts its price. Radheshyam has had to abandon his studies, yet in the eyes of Kameshar's children he is Superman from the comics.

"Things": A husband and wife manage their household and its petty irritations. Problems at the office interrupt the narrative in italic type on three occasions. There is the craving for supplementary income, the husband's rebukes to his wife and her replies.

"Greed": The manufacture of money and the greed for earning it receive an effective analysis. This can be placed among humorous and satirical stories, and now and then one feels an echo of Chekhov. The officer tells the protagonist, "You may be good at idle conversation, but you have no talent for running an industry devoted to making money."

"The Feast": A person who has undergone the *upanayana* cannot eat at a *śrāddha* feast for a year. A Maithil discussion of ritual feasting is presented through the eyes of a Brahmin boy. An outstanding children's story.

"A Question of Happiness": Also based upon child psychology, this account of a family is presented from a boy protagonist's point of view. Another outstanding children's story.

"The Tanpura": The glamour Bhimsen Joshi brought to classical music is evidenced by his Mercedes car and the Bharat Ratna conferred upon him later. His declaration, upon accepting the Bharat Ratna, that he received it on behalf of the great teachers of music was dignified. Those very custodians kept alive the two Indian classical traditions—Hindustani and Carnatic—alongside Western classical music, often at the cost of their own subsistence. "The Tanpura" narrates the death of such livelihoods. Sharadindu Chaudhary has written memoirs, in his own manner, about the plight of block printing after the arrival of offset machines. Likewise,

Jagdanand Jha "Manu" wrote the children's story "Earthen Vessels" about potters after metal utensils displaced their ware.

"Harsinghdevi" concerns the harmful consequences of the *pañjī* genealogy system. Its subject is good, but the treatment is ordinary and essayistic.

"The Well-Wisher of Siwan Rajak" brings caste, politics and Siwan Rajak's bank employment into the narrative. Even the final image, "they uprooted him from the thicket and planted him in a flowerpot," cannot rescue the story.

"Mahto" is another caste-based tale. It concerns an ordinary salaried employee, Mahto, employed as a gardener. We encounter coded terminology for percentages of bribes, Mahto's working in his officers' houses as well as the office, office gossip, and politics—and the story ends. I expected more from Ashok's stories named after Rajak and Mahto, but they seem exercises in filling a quota.

"A Message": Executive Engineer Paswanji harshly berates Diwakar Ravidas after he stops tutoring Paswanji's child. Some essay-like Dalit discourse follows. To introduce a turn at the end, the author has Diwakar ask the protagonist for his steel ring and return a gold ring of the same size. This produces only a little theatrical effect. The story is a pale shadow of O. Henry's "The Gift of the Magi."

"Attachment and Detachment": A story about the ways wealthy and cunning people cheat innocent people with encouragement and reassuring talk. It rises above the ordinary.

"Impulse": A mediocre story. The mother's emotional outburst is described, but adolescent psychology is suppressed, leaving the story one-sided.

"The Old Man Continued to Live" exemplifies Ashok's distinctive strength and area of expertise. It is the fault of dull mainstream criticism that he was never made aware of this strength; he nevertheless recognised it himself and wrote more stories of this kind in his final collection. The old man has no real intention of marrying, declaring that he will not marry a woman over eighteen. Even when an eighteen-year-old proposal arrives, he finds another pretext. Yet in entertaining the matchmakers he goes far beyond the customary serving of *śarbat*. He laughs even after the deaths of his wife and three sons, because he wants to live. Still, he must sometimes lament, in his loneliness—and he does so before his pupil Sattan.

"Inverse" is another mediocre story, mixing village gossip and backbiting, funeral rites and caste discussion into a single narrative. These strands needed to be disentangled and developed more patiently.

"The Widow" is above average, like "The Old Man Continued to Live." It has three flashpoints. First, the aunt asks Manish whether Sirajuddin is really bad; if he is a decent person, why could Manish not convince his father? Second, she asks what is wrong with working and earning money. Third, Manish admires her dressing well even after her husband's death. The statement that Manish is surprised to see his aunt in such clothes weakens the craftsmanship: after showing so firm a character, the writer should have made Manish surprised if he saw her in white widow's clothing. That is where the drama was needed; the author misses it. Compared with the first two flashpoints, the third feels somewhat insipid. The story is the aunt's, and its opening is sound, but a sequence marker or dash could have marked the transition to the flashback. Had a different narrative technique been used to depict the village's other widow, the story might have reached the highest rank.

Daddygaon (Short-Story Collection, 2017)

Dedicated to Dida, the late Geeta Devi, *Daddygaon* contains fifteen stories by Ashok.

"A Kick" is a story about a flamboyant kurta; extremely ordinary, it belongs to the category of diary-like writing.

"Deception" is Ashok's finest story, of an exceptionally high order. Vidyanand Jha has translated it into English with only ordinary competence [in *The Book of Bihari Literature*, edited by Abhay K., HarperCollins, 2022]; nevertheless, the story is so powerful that it comes alive even in that translation. Its psychology is that the soul of the person one acts will enter one's own being. Perform the role of Vidyapati grieving for Ugna, and tears will flow without glycerine. Bholi Jha is clever and resourceful, yet precisely such a soul has entered her.

"Independent" is based on marital rape, but the author becomes preoccupied with writing upon a sociological issue, leaving the story ordinary.

"The Two of Them Learn to Ride Bicycles" is also based on a contemporary problem, but neither the problem is convincingly realised nor the story properly untangled.

"Daddygaon" is the title story. As with "The Dawn of That Night" and "Mātbar," Ashok chooses his most cherished story for the title and adds prop upon prop, yet all three title stories remain ordinary. "Daddygaon" follows a routine sequence concerning development, confusion and commotion.

"Rāg" is another ordinary tale of Hindu–Muslim friendship, with conversation about meat.

"Lemon Ice Cream" is a high-quality story, a true Ashok story. The protagonist's mother used to say, when he cooked well, "It tastes as though it came from a hotel." His wife Meera, however, disliked hotels. She died. As long as his son and daughter were with him, the protagonist had no interest whatever in cooking. The son went to the village, and everyone gathered around him affectionately, praising his mother and praising him. And then...

"Umki" almost becomes an outstanding story. It contains much material on sexist behaviour, and its ending is good. "Your companion is always making you dance anyway. What dance can you show merely by dancing?" lends it a measure of suspense. Yet something is missing.

"Intention" tells of a collapsing family and its emotions. Artificial life has no place for feeling or social institutions; the writer becomes cruel towards his subject, and the story remains ordinary.

"Abhay's Son Has Two Teeth" is an outstanding story. The village is no longer fit to live in, but...

"Life Is the Name of Happiness": Kanhaiya Babu's son finally agrees to marry, and Kanhaiya is happy. The young man is a Maithil Brahmin, the girl a Nair from Kerala. The story concludes by saying that the bride from Kerala is just like us. An ordinary story.

"A Pang": This reads like a tale derived from a case file, and the case itself is commonplace: a husband forges his wife's signature to embezzle money, the wife accepts responsibility, and there is imprisonment. The story is consequently ordinary too.

"A Day's Leave" treats problems of reading and writing in Maithili, with digressions and an inter-caste love marriage. It ends with the proverb that quarrelsome people find even elephant-foot yam irritating, but Abhinav will not. An ordinary, essay-like story.

"The Highway at the Edge of the Village" concerns ring roads. Umesh Paswan writes, "The ghostly turning on the national highway has become a crossroads of death" [*Bhutahā Moṛ*, in *Varṇit Raṣ*, 2012, a work awarded the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Yuva Puraskar]. On national highways crossroads are now routinely called "ghostly bends," because deficient design and a lack of flyovers cause accidents. I too wrote a poem upon this subject:

> And then what a magnificent sight our village would have been!
> What a magnificent sight this six-lane road would have presented!
> We too would have worn clothes
> Just like those

Worn by the child sitting in that red car!
Mother!
I always felt
This road through our village
Was closer to us than that red car belonging to the foreigner;
Yet both of them looked foreign.

(Gajendra Thakur, "The Great Six-Lane Road," *Kurukshetram Antarmanak*, 2009)

The settlement has died and withered; this national highway seems determined to swallow the village. Dogs are dying throughout the village. The story is high-quality reportage.

"Someone Like This": Boroline, Boroplus and black-and-white television provide material for nostalgic reportage. Then the description of Chaudhary Sahib begins; the story wanders without purpose, obsessed with appearing attractive, praising women, before a junior becomes angry and Chaudharyji's eyes are opened. This purposeless story ends with an ordinary joke.

Ashok has written few short stories, and few of those attain the highest rank. His distinguishing strength is an awareness of modern social problems, a variety of subjects, and a fine capacity to dissect psychology and emotion. Yet his art of clarifying and developing the subject frequently fails because he wants a punchline ending; those punchlines are sometimes very ordinary and repetitive. Again and again I am reminded of the refined narrative technique of Sushil, his mastery of storytelling and his gift for writing new-modern stories.

Gajendra Thakur

Ashok the Writer of Non-fictional Prose

"Father, I am leaving the home of my girlhood;
That threshold has become a mountain, and the courtyard a foreign land."

Ashok the Writer of Non-fictional Prose

Ashok's non-fictional prose includes *Maithil Āṅkhi* (2007), *Saṃvād* (a collection of interviews, 2007), *Kathāk Upanyās: Upanyāsak Kathā* (2012), *Āṅkhime Basal* (travel writing, 2013), *Bāt-Vichār* (criticism, 2015), *Nīk Dinak Bāiskop* (satirical writing, 2018), *Rajmohan Jha* (an extended essay, 2019), and *Kathā-Pāṭh* (2022). There is also criticism and other non-fiction scattered through Videha and elsewhere: for example, "More Unmaking than Making" (on Subhash Chandra Yadav's *Banait Bigarait*), "Editor Rajnandan Lal Das and *Karṇāmṛta*," "Reading Ramlochan

Thakur's Poetry," work on Kedarnath Chaudhary's novel, writings on Sharadinduji, and others.

In *Saṃvād*, Ashok interviews Rajmohan Jha, Dhumketu, Kulanand Mishra and Mohan Bhardwaj. He is unable to ask any of them an uncomfortable question: whether it concerns Rajmohan Jha's alleged compromise in connection with Subhash Chandra Yadav's monograph on Rajkamal Chaudhary and the Sahitya Akademi award (see my *Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav*, Gajendra Thakur, 2022, available in the Videha archive); Dhumketu's writing with the red flag as a prop; or Mohan Bhardwaj's description of Maithil Brahmin ritual songs as the ritual songs of all Mithila (see the volume he edited for the Maithili Academy). Later Umesh Mandal collected the ritual songs of all castes, which were published electronically by Videha and constitute the genuine ritual-song traditions of Mithila. Yet, in "A Day's Leave" (*Daddygaon*, 2017), Ashok did raise all the questions that he had not managed to ask. An interview with Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary could not take place because of the latter's death; instead Ashok brought out *Sandhān*, issue 3, devoted to Prabhas.

Āṅkhime Basal (travel writing, 2013) describes the narrative presented to Ashok's generation, in which the Soviet Union was celebrated and America derided, even while those who propagated it sent their sons and daughters to America for education. I remember a friend who travelled to Darbhanga for an examination, walked around the university neighbourhood and declared on his return that no other city in Bihar was as fine as Darbhanga. Beyond his travel writing, Ashok did the same thing in the poem "From Soviet Russia" (*Chakravyūha*, 1986).

Maithil Āṅkhi (2007), *Kathāk Upanyās: Upanyāsak Kathā* (2012), *Bāt-Vichār* (2015) and *Kathā-Pāṭh* (2022) are collections of his essays and essay-like critical pieces.

The following points emerge in favour of, and against, Ashok's criticism and essays:

(1) His work offers evidence of studying only mainstream writers. He seems unaware of the contributions of the parallel current over the last fifteen years—or perhaps he fears that mentioning them will estrange him from the mainstream. In "The Development of the Maithili Short Story: Changing Voices and Tendencies," he says that Jivakant wrote more stories than any other Maithili author and puts the number at two hundred. He has not yet felt a need to revise that article in the light of new evidence, although Jagdish Prasad Mandal has written 850 stories so far.

(2) His criticism of living writers consists chiefly of praise and description. If criticism of a living author never identifies weaknesses, how can that

author improve? One example is "The Mirage of Migration to a Distant Land and the Struggle of a Working Woman—*Hasina Manzil*." In criticism of deceased writers he shows somewhat more courage, as in "Lalit's *Pṛthvīputra*," but there he creates further confusion. He asks: "The natural question here is why, while writing a novel about the struggles of cultivators, Lalit introduced the love story of Kalpu and Bijli. Why did he think it necessary to raise a social problem such as marriage between a Brahmin and an untouchable? Why did a conscious writer like Lalit needlessly take on this burden?" In the final line of his article, Ashok explains his reasoning: "In fact, this conception of Lalit's Maithil *saṃskāra* is a product of casteist ideology." In support, he invokes a conversation between Lalit and Ramdev Jha, although such a prop is unnecessary. Love and sex are perennial subjects; neither famine nor plague can abolish them. Ashok needed no external justification. Gabriel García Márquez's *Love in the Time of Cholera* is proof enough.

(3) *Nīk Dinak Bāiskop*, his collection of satire, gave Ashok an opportunity to say everything he wished, in the manner of the exuberant *jogīrā* sung at Holi. He missed that opportunity too.

53. A Study of Būchjī's Poetry from Marxist, Historical, Structuralist, Magical-Realist, Postmodern, Feminist and Deconstructionist Perspectives, as Well as from Indian Aesthetics

Abstract

In his poem "Jeṭhī Kareh," Būchjī says that the river rises turbulently in the morning and overflows even when rainfall has diminished. The danger mark lies very high, so why does the river remain restless? At the end he suggests that it will break through the embankment and unleash a catastrophe. This is the ordinary, surface reading of the poem.

Keywords: Būch; poetry; Marxism; structuralism; deconstruction; postmodernity; Indian aesthetics; *sphoṭa*

"Jeṭhī Kareh"

In Būchjī's poem "Jeṭhī Kareh," the poet says that the river rises in turbulence in the morning and overflows despite a decrease in rainfall. The danger mark stands very high; why, then, is the river so agitated? He ends by predicting that the river will break its embankment and work destruction. That is a general reading. From a structuralist standpoint, the statement that the Kareh rises turbulently in the morning implies that perhaps it does not rise so at other times. It overflows despite less rain, although one would expect otherwise. The shimmering of its water, whirlpools at the bends, and their effect—the river drawing the very heart of the village mound into itself—come together as a structure. The rise in its sandbanks unsettles the poet's patience. Let us move away from structuralism to historical analysis. The poem will acquire a new meaning in a new era. The danger mark that appeared very high in the poet's time is no longer so high, because silt has accumulated between the embankments and raised the riverbed. For a new generation the poem thus assumes a form different from the poet's original conception. Now turn from structuralism towards deconstruction. A deconstructionist would contend that the structuralist's poles take on philosophical dimensions. Reduced rainfall accompanied by flooding, the foolishness of engineers attempting to imprison the Kareh behind embankments, and the poet's prediction that the river will tear the embankments apart and cause devastation—all raise questions about whether the poet's polarisation is lasting or temporary. Let us return to the poem's historicity. In magical-realist literature, if we travel back into the past, we see the spirit of dam-building possessing people in the 1960s: dams, lofty and broad, that would restrain rivers and supposedly shower blessings upon human beings. If this poem

reached a character inhabiting such a magical-realist world, the character would give it yet another meaning. The poet's own presence would dissolve, and the science of language would begin its play. A magical-realist character inhabiting the future would also interpret it differently: unable to comprehend the poet's claim that the river's danger mark stood high, the character would seek the feeling that animated the poem. But deconstruction would then become entangled in its own net. Much would be left unsaid, and still much would remain to be said. Rain would endure, and the river would remain, though in a transformed state; its waters would continue to shimmer in the sunlight. Rising turbulence and overflowing would persist.

"A Song of Welcome"

A general reading: the poet welcomes everyone, yet asks what song of celebration can be sung amid the anguished cries of Mithila's eroding earth. The bees are thirsty and the fruit trees wither: what use is this ceremonial gathering? One must bring a staff along with poetry and a rough implement of labour alongside the flow of *rasa*. Beneath the poem appears a note: "Welcome to the guests at the Vidyapati Memorial Festival, 1984, village Baidyanathpur, Rosera block, Samastipur district." This was the period when migration from Mithila was beginning. The bridge over the Ganges at Hajipur had been built. The model of development seemed to have failed; disillusionment with large embankments had set in. The catastrophe of floods afflicted farming and farmers, while industrialisation based on local crops was absent and campaigns for education were nowhere visible. In these circumstances the poet had undertaken the duty of welcoming the guests. Consider *dhvani* theory. In the *Dhvanyāloka*, Ānandavardhana argues that literature's purpose is to suggest or generate meaning indirectly. The theory describes the structure and functioning of implied meaning and is related to *rasa*, the experience of aesthetic relish, and *alaṃkāra*, figures of speech. Ānandavardhana regards *dhvani*, suggestion, as the soul of poetry. Meaning may emerge obliquely through suggestion, but it emerges in an organised fashion; hence theories of meaning and symbol, and the production of *rasa*, become important. Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā opposed this theory, denying an independent existence to *dhvani* and regarding its effects as inference already covered by the category of secondary indication (*lakṣaṇā*). Not everything, they argued, could be directly stated in words. Read "A Song of Welcome" through *dhvani*. By declaring that Vidyapati, the Shiva-like conqueror of death, is dead, the poet brings meaning and symbol into view together. Nyāya opposed *dhvani* theory, but Būchjī, a poet from Kariyan, the village of the Nyāya philosopher Udayana, is a poet rather than a philosopher. He gives suggestion a powerful structure: our ill fortune has become deeply rooted and enduring; what will this ceremonial gathering alone

accomplish? He continues: "Recite poetry, but carry a staff upon your shoulder; let one hand hold the source of *rasa*, the other the rough tool." Filled with such symbols, the poem moves forward with coherence as it welcomes the visitors. From a Marxist standpoint, the poet's task exceeds the simple recitation of verse. Affirmation and negation, the old and the new, development and death have been combined successfully. Had "A Song of Welcome" detached itself from its circumstances to offer applause and empty praise, it would have been an inferior poem from a Marxist perspective, like so many conventional Maithili songs of welcome and celebrations of wealth. Instead, the poet makes the song part of a dynamic process, transforming it into Maithili's finest welcome song.

"The Daughter Became a Mountain"

A general reading of "The Daughter Became a Mountain": the cherished daughter has become a water jar hanging from her father's neck. She arrived on a flying conveyance, but now forsakes Hari's Garuda and demands a car. Thirty-five grams of gold have been furnished, yet there are further demands for wedding-night expenses and a ten-vehicle marriage procession. Electric bulbs shine everywhere, but darkness remains at the very centre. Dasharatha did not ask for a single coin; Rama said nothing. History tells of Krishna's love marriage, but what of that? In the present, Janaka cries out in despair. The father holds his son by the throat; homes have become slaughterhouses and villages markets. From the standpoint of sociological criticism, the poem opposes the system of onerous marriage demands or dowry. In that period, as even now, the custom has made the cherished daughter who seemed to arrive upon a flying vehicle a source of exhaustion and anxiety for her father.

"A Song of Sorrow"

A general reading of "A Song of Sorrow": hearing the cuckoo's plaintive song, one sees a flowering grove through tear-filled eyes. On a golden summit of valour, a readily attained victory of the ocean of peace! Whenever an embrace seems possible, innumerable crooked thorns pierce the flesh. Beauty came for two moments—and went away. Love's honey turned bitter. Night's weeping melts into dawn. A formalist reading: examine the flowering grove seen through streaming eyes, the terrible aspect of a burning cremation ground appearing upon the bridal bed, and the easy victory of an ocean of peace upon the golden summit of valour. The poet employs the defamiliarising aspect of language particularly well, and this gives his poem its poetic quality. Contradictory words, their unfamiliar combinations, and language rich in sound figures make the poem distinctive. Thorns piercing like flowers and other such combinations give it formalist excellence.

"It Is the Village I Remember"

A general reading: in the village there might have been barely enough bread and the poorest greens without salt, yet it is the village that the speaker remembers from Calcutta. If water from the Kareh could be used to cultivate pearls, would the children have to scatter? Would it be better to remain a gentleman on the Hooghly or a labourer on the banks of the Kamala? The woods beside the Kamala are lovelier than Eden Gardens. There a husband adorns his wife with a garland, whereas in the woods by the Kamala a woman of Tirhut searches for *dhaturā* and *ākoṇ* flowers to offer her Bhola, Shiva. A feminist reading: this is a poem of migration. The Tirhut woman searches for flowers for Bhola, while her Bhola lives away from home. From an existentialist standpoint, this Bhola is responsible for his own circumstances, solitary existence and worries.

"Son Dai"

A general reading: neither laughter nor pleasure will enter Son Dai's life—but why? Groups of children depart; young people follow, and the elderly wither away. Yet why does Son Dai continue to trust? The answer appears later: she has forgotten her homeland and spends her life in migration. As age advances, how long can she go on living in Son Dai's house? From a feminist standpoint, theories about women, even theories of poetry, made by men in a male-centred society are not appropriate to women. For whose sake has Son Dai forgotten her homeland and endured a migrant existence?

"Famine"

A general reading of "Famine": the poet describes hunger as a torch tied to a tail, beating time upon a raised platform. Drought brings famine, and famine rising prices, until the sky over the burning village becomes red. Death performs a dance of destruction in India as in Lanka; this time even Vibhishana's house will not escape, for a garland of heads is tied together with cord. Mother embraces the earth in her arms; ten-headed Ravana opens all twenty eyes and shakes his heads. The theory of *aucitya*, or propriety: in the *Aucityavicāracarcā*, Kshemendra treats propriety as the principal element of literature. Where should propriety reside? In a word, sentence, the meaning of an entire composition, literary quality, figure of speech, *rasa*, grammatical case, action, gender, number, adjective, prefix, particle, time, place, family, observance, essential truth, inner quality, intention, nature, selection of essentials, talent, condition, reflection, name and benediction. The universe trembles, existing as vibration alone. After a poem is read, peace spreads everywhere, even through the mind. A reading of "Famine" from *aucitya*: this is not merely a famine but Time as the Great Destroyer—hunger's torch tied to a tail beating its rhythm on

the platform. Within the time and place of Mithila, this description of famine is appropriate to the poem. Ravana must be uprooted; Vibhishana too will not survive.

"Your Lips"

A general reading of "Your Lips": lips reddened by *pān* and the lips of a beautiful woman. She applies the lime of speech and adorns her cheeks with drops red as *katthā*, the catechu used in *pān*. But where is the pipe that sounds the tune of love? The redness of dawn resembles her lips, and without her the speaker is like an anxious evening. If an executioner is to become her husband, he will become the dismembered Rahu. Nectar is rare even in heaven; where, then, can one find lips like hers? The Sakri sugar mill will become great when he learns science from Vishvakarma; sweetness will flow out of that mill. Her lips resemble a ripe segment of sugarcane. Even in rebirth he will come to her as paddy and delicately cooked rice. Yet after all this, the intended purpose is still not revealed through words. A reading through *alaṃkāra* theory: Bhāmaha regards figures of speech in terms of *samāsokti*, the expression that becomes a source of pleasure. Daṇḍin and Udbhaṭa developed the theory further. Figures of speech fall primarily into two classes, those based upon sound and those upon meaning, and further into resemblance, contrast, logical inference, common-world reasoning, poetic convention and apprehension of hidden significance. Mammaṭa divides sixty-one figures into seven groups: *upamā* (simile), *rūpaka* (metaphor), *aprastuta* (indirect praise), *dīpaka* (a figure of distributed illumination), *vyatireka* (contrast), *virodha* (contradiction), and *samuccaya* (combination). "Applying the lime of speech" is indirect expression. "Cheeks with red drops like *katthā*," "lips red with *pān* and the woman's lips," "the blush of dawn like her lips," and "her lips like a ripe joint of sugarcane" are among the poet's similes. "Where is the sounding reed of love?" expresses tension between similarity and difference, while "anxious in the middle of the road without you" employs metaphor. The Indian conception of poetry: art as a path to liberation. Consider Nataraja's posture, where the rhythms of creation and destruction are simultaneously visible. The enduring emotion is intensified and matured into *rasa*—and how many such experiences of *rasa* did Sita and Rama undergo (see Vālmīki's *Rāmāyaṇa*)? Krishna is a teacher of the Indian doctrine of action, and at the same time a connoisseur of pleasure. A theory of *rasa* was needed to account for the savour of art, and Bharata composed the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Abhinavagupta wrote a commentary on Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka*. Bhāmaha in the sixth century, Daṇḍin in the seventh, and Rudraṭa in the ninth developed related lines of thought. A reading of "Your Lips" through *rasa* theory: for Bharata, the performance of drama produces *rasa*. What is drama for? For the enactment of *rasa*, but also for bringing *rasa* into being. How is it

produced? Through *vibhāva* (determinants or causes), *anubhāva* (expressive manifestations or consequences), and *vyabhicāribhāva* (associated or transitory states). The enduring emotion matures into *rasa* and becomes something we can relish. For Bhaṭṭa Lollaṭa, the enduring emotion intensifies through cause and effect until it becomes *rasa*. Actors and actresses experience it through research and imagination. Lollaṭa gives little importance to the poet or to the listener-spectator. Śaṅkuka holds that, to experience *rasa*, the spectator must enter the performance imaginatively, much as one appreciates an image of a horse by apprehending it as a horse. Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka says that *rasa* acts upon the spectator and treats poetic language as distinct from ordinary language. Through *rasa* the soul of the listener-spectator unites with the supreme soul. The pleasure of *rasa* is the enjoyment of one's own essential being, yielding self-realisation. *Rasa* theory is founded upon the listener, spectator and reader; these are its emphases. In the passage "You applied the stone-lime of speech / and adorned your cheeks with the blood-red *katthā*," we have *vibhāva*, the determining cause; "seeing this, my heart surged" is *anubhāva*, its expressive consequence. The theory of *sphoṭa*: Bhartṛhari's *Vākyapadīya* holds that the meaning of a word or sentence is conveyed through an integrated burst of apprehension, *sphoṭa*. Through *varṇa-sphoṭa*, letters are apprehended; through *pada-sphoṭa*, words; and through *vākya-sphoṭa*, sentences. No knowledge is possible without some relation to words. This became part of Indian epistemology. Meaning can be communicated without the simultaneous physical presence of letters, words and sentences. *Sphoṭa* is *śabdabrahman*, the verbal absolute, and the fundamental cause of creation. Letters, words and sentences do not exist simultaneously as complete wholes. The separate sounds of an uttered word do not individually possess the full meaning; until the word is complete, they arise and perish. In *sphoṭa*, meaning is apprehended even though the letters, words or sentence do not all exist at the moment of apprehension or transmission. Until the word is complete, each successive letter contributes to a sequence of signification, just as successive words do until a sentence is complete. Sāṃkhya, Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta reject *sphoṭa*, holding instead that letters and their sounds adequately establish meaning. Jacques Derrida's theories of deconstruction and dissemination come close to *sphoṭa*. A reading of "Your Lips" through *sphoṭa*: although Būchjī lives on the soil of Udayana's Kariyan, Nyāya's rejection of *sphoṭa* is not enough to account for his poetry. Having spoken every secret thought held in his heart, he compares the elusive thief of his mind to the beautiful woman's lips.

Būch, the poet from Udayana's village, writes of letters exhausting themselves, one by one, and of the purpose remaining unrevealed by words. The manner in which he communicates meaning not simply

through words but through *sphoṭa* in "Your Lips" and the other poems in this collection presents Būchjī as Maithili's most rhythmic poet after Vidyapati. In Yehudi Menuhin's words, Maithili is the world's most rhythmic and melodious language. Būchjī's poetry redefines Maithili verse in this form.

Drama and Theatre

54. Nachiketa's Play *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*

Abstract

The Plot of the Play—First Kallola: This play is divided into kallolas in the tradition of Jyotirishwar. His Varṇaratnākara is divided into kallolas, although it is not a play; his play Dhūrtasamāgama is divided into acts. The first of the four kallolas begins at the entrance to heaven—or perhaps hell—where many dead people wait in a queue to be allowed inside.

Keywords: Nachiketa; drama; *No Entry*; *Mā Praviśa*; literary criticism; Maithili

The Plot—First *Kallola*: This play is divided into *kallolas* in the tradition of Jyotirishwar. His *Varṇaratnākara* is divided into *kallolas*, although it is not a play, whereas his play *Dhūrtasamāgama* is divided into acts. The first of four *kallolas* opens at the gate of heaven—or hell—where a large number of the deceased are queuing to enter. There is a city gentleman who died in a road accident, along with soldiers killed in war, thieves killed while stealing, rogues and pickpockets. The ultramodern absurdity of Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrtasamāgama* is evident also in *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*. In the first *kallola*, when a thief and a ruffian break the queue and go forward, the city gentleman seizes each of them by the collar and returns them to their places. The ruffian, later revealed as a gang boss, tells him to let go of his shirt, but is momentarily restrained by the gentleman's imposing manner. When a pickpocket speaks from the gentleman's side against the thief, the ruffian draws a knife, reveals his true nature and launches himself at the pickpocket. The thief explains that the pickpocket belongs to their own fraternity but has only managed to become a petty pickpocket, not a skilled thief like himself, and could never even dream of being a hardened thug like the ruffian. The ruffian now turns on the thief: whom did he just call a thug? The pickpocket quickly changes sides and tells the ruffian that the insult was aimed at him, not at the ruffian. He adds that the thief is so incompetent at his craft that a householder's sons and dogs beat him to death while he was stealing—and yet he dares ridicule a pickpocket and call himself a great thief! The respectable man cannot believe that someone who speaks so fluently could actually be a thief, so the pickpocket teases "His Majesty the Thief" still further. The thief then laments that, had he known, he would never have taken this pickpocket along to steal that night, nor would he have been able to bear seeing him beaten. The city gentleman, who earlier dragged the thief and ruffian back by their collars, listens in silence and wonders what sort of heaven it will be if he must live there with such people. He recites a fragment of song upon the subject. As in *Dhūrtasamāgama*, songs are interspersed throughout *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*; the singing begins here and makes this a musical play. Meanwhile the pickpocket empties

everyone's pockets and wallets. Another musical refrain begins, but a dead ragpicker interrupts the spell by observing that beyond the closed gate of Yama's realm, money and purses are of no use. The two deceased respectable men agree: the currency of one country is not accepted in another. A dead romantic gentleman named Ramani Mohan comments that changing countries' currencies is much like one's beloved becoming someone else's wife. An argument begins, so Ramani Mohan changes the subject to the Apsaras Rambha and Menaka who may be waiting inside. A beggar woman, who has passed the doll she was cradling to someone else in order to join the argument, jealously abuses Rambha and Menaka as sharp-tongued women. The pickpocket points out that the other side may contain sorrow as readily as happiness. This delights an insurance agent, who sees an opportunity to expand his business. The pickpocket then begins soliciting bids, in rupees, for Indra's thunderbolt. The city gentleman interrupts the proceedings, and the respectable men support him: what an extraordinary auction, run by a pickpocket with the thief and beggar woman bidding! They have never heard of its like. Another musical refrain starts. Just then Nandi and Bhringi enter, dancing to classical music. Asked by Nandi and Bhringi what lies beyond the door, each character answers according to his or her beliefs: heaven or hell, the heights of the sky or the depths below. Nandi and Bhringi tell them that each has spoken the truth, yet none has spoken the whole truth. They begin listing the deaths: one was killed while stealing (at which the thief tries to run away, only to be brought back by two or three others), one in an accident, and so on. But even Nandi and Bhringi cannot explain how the insurance agent arrived here without dying. He declares that he has come prospecting for a new market! Thus one person is present without being dead. Bhringi explains to Nandi the fierce competition brought about by the arrival of so many insurance companies. Meanwhile the lovers quarrel because the young man wants to go back. Ramani Mohan is delighted at the prospect of the young man's departure: the woman will be alone and he will have his chance. Bhringi says that leaving this place is impossible, though the couple might go and arrange for their respective parents to die in accidents and join them. The lovers refuse to sacrifice their parents for their own convenience. Nandi and Bhringi therefore marry the pair with music and ceremonial instruments, the city gentleman performing the giving away of the bride.

Second *Kallola*: The scene opens with the expectation that a political leader will arrive after his death. Two of his followers have already died and reached the waiting area. Everyone awaits Netaji, while the two followers make short speeches, with songs, to compensate for his lateness—even after death. The thief fails to understand a song, but the beggar woman and ragpicker understand it, prompting an argument. The thief objects to

being called a thief; when he calls the woman a beggar, she protests: she is Anasuya of Sarisav-Pahi, a Mithila painter. Only after arriving in Delhi's Ashok Basti did she discover that no one in the city would buy art objects, so she became a beggar at the crossroads. The thief claims that only he has earned a bad name, for everyone steals. Nothing is new; everything is a theft from the past. Netaji then arrives and attributes the presence of thieves, ruffians and pickpockets to social conditions. A leftist arrives too and is offended to find Netaji surrounded by such people. But the thief again advances his own argument, and the city gentleman launches into song upon Netaji's expression "the Purāṇa of Thieves."

Third *Kallola*: Discussion turns to a coalition between Netaji and the leftist, and to the leftist's external support for the government. Netaji again begins to sing, but attention shifts when a deceased actor, Vivek Kumar, arrives in a stunt-like entrance. Netaji satirises the compulsion to supply instant "breaking news." Twice the leftist says something new: first, that no one can become a political leader without first becoming an actor; second, that a thief cannot become a leader (so the thief asserts), whereas politicians themselves lag behind no one in stealing. Just then a high-born woman arrives. After she is questioned, a VIP queue forms alongside the ordinary queue. The actor, political leader and leftist promptly stand in the VIP line! When asked why they have formed a queue at all, the thief and pickpocket answer that they are practised at forming queues—and breaking them.

Fourth *Kallola*: Yama examines everyone's accounts and records. Chitragupta reveals that there was once an age when the door in front of them opened and closed. Nandi and Bhringi have already warned them that the supposed door was no dream, but an error of perception. Asked what lies beyond, everyone gives a different answer, and Chitragupta says that everything in their descriptions is indeed there. Nandi and Bhringi announce that entry through this gate is forbidden: the sign says "NO ENTRY." Alas, what are they to do? Netaji is sent before Yama, but his eloquence deserts him. The famous politician Badri Vishal Mishra is questioned about having understated his age on a certificate. It says fifty-five, but the astrological *Śaśa Yoga* indicates that he will live beyond seventy. He is therefore sent back, along with the four soldiers. Two soldiers accompany Netaji, and the leader's two followers wish to leave too. Their crimes, however, are too serious. On Chitragupta's orders Nandi and Bhringi take the followers away to be roasted in a cauldron; the other two soldiers seize and lead them away, and Nandi and Bhringi return to the stage. After further debate, the lovers, the two respectable men and the city gentleman are also granted release, leaving to the sound of drums and pipes. Nandi then announces the actor as "Vivek Kumar, alias..." but the actor interrupts: after so much effort he has managed to leave his caste

identity behind, so please omit the "alias." When the actor mentions assisting a leftist meeting, the leftist contradicts him. The actor too is sent back. What of the leftist? His ideology has neither heaven nor hell, neither Yama nor Chitragupta. He is offered the opportunity to decide his own future, but says that although his education taught him otherwise, how can he disbelieve what is happening before his eyes? Yama answers that what he sees might be a nightmare: everywhere he seeks to enter he will find the words "NO ENTRY." Yama then asks who is unequal or unjust—human beings or nature? The leftist answers: both. Nature sometimes operates according to natural justice, but where is any prospect of such justice in human nature? Leftist politics nevertheless attempts to secure equality and reform. Yama sends the thief, the ruffian and the pickpocket with him, inviting him to change them. The thief hesitates and asks: "We are going, but what lies beyond?" Nandi, Chitragupta and Yama respond together: "NO ENTRY." Bhringi now returns, having escorted the actor away. Yama says, "*Mā praviśa*—do not enter." Bhringi reports what people are saying below: everywhere there is talk that the rules here will be changed and that many people are to be allowed to return to earth. Yama's messengers stand idly beside their cauldrons, having found no one to roast —except the two followers. Everyone agrees that no arrivals remain. Chitragupta removes his long beard and Yama his crown, revealing two ordinary human beings beneath the costumes! The beggar woman, who is still there, laughs at Chitragupta's long theatrical beard. Bhringi reveals that the beggar woman is an actor just like themselves. What acting! Their exchange about it ends with love and playful teasing, but the beggar woman says that the real performance is happening "over there," pointing to the romance developing between Ramani Mohan and Nibha, the high-born woman. Nibha, however, says nothing. The beggar woman tells Yama that Nibha will speak only when she receives the key to the locked door; she will imagine that Yama can help make her an Apsara. The heart of this romantic woman, too, bears the sign "NO ENTRY." Yama coughs, and Chitragupta realises that Yama has been struck by the five arrows of the god of love. At Chitragupta's instruction everyone leaves the stage except Yama and Nibha. Facing her, Yama begins, "Listen, Nibha..." and stops. Encouraged by the others, he gives her an enormous key, but once she has it she walks away with Ramani Mohan as though she did not know Yama at all. She passes the key to Ramani Mohan, who cannot open the lock. Nibha steps forward to try, but Chitragupta says that this is the door of the mind and cannot be opened in that manner. The woman protests that they have been given the key only to be deceived. Everyone laughs: "Where have you left your mind?" Once again Ramani Mohan and Nibha attempt, unsuccessfully, to join their minds and unlock the door. Nandi, Bhringi and the beggar woman sing of the lock upon the heart and its sign "NO ENTRY." Yet spring brings endless love, and the heart calls "Maina,

Maina." Therefore, they resolve to stage a sit-in right there before the "NO ENTRY" door.

Critical Discussion: A comparative study of Indian and Western theories of drama shows how remarkably similar human thinking can remain despite geographical distances. Indian dramaturgy is grounded principally in Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* and Dhanañjaya's *Daśarūpaka*. The authoritative Western text is Aristotle's *Poetics*.

Bharata calls drama an imitation of action (*kṛtānusāra*) and an imitation of emotion (*bhāvānukāra*), while Dhanañjaya defines it as the imitation of a condition. In Indian literary theory, imitation is the actor's work, not the poet's. In the West, imitation is understood as the poet's work; the actor is not discussed in the same way.

Aristotle places special emphasis on plot. Tragedy comprises plot, characterisation, diction, thought, spectacle and song. Bharata distinguishes the principal plot concerning the hero, *ādhikārika*, from an incidental plot that aids it, *prāsaṅgika*. Not every play, however, must have an incidental plot. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* has neither a conventionally central plot nor a subsidiary one, because it has no universally acknowledged hero. The city gentleman who seizes the ruffian by the collar soon becomes a minor figure. The thief who cowers before the ruffian later emerges as a spokesman for the philosophy that nothing is truly new. Yama, who terrifies everyone, finds his authority weakened before Nibha. When the beggar woman laughs at his removal of the divine costume, Ramani Mohan and Nibha even abuse him and Chitragupta at the end. The leftist and the actor undergo comparable reversals. No character is inherently weak; each rebounds and changes in response to time and circumstance.

From the perspective of narrative source, plots fall into three groups: *prakhyāta*, drawn from known history or the Purāṇas; *utpādya*, invented; and *miśra*, combining both. The possibility of calling *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* a mixed plot ends when Chitragupta and Yama remove their false costumes and Bhringi, after the beggar woman laughs, identifies her as an actor like themselves. Names such as Yama and Chitragupta alone do not make a story historical or Purāṇic; its plot is wholly invented. Aristotle distinguishes simple and complex plots. The ease and fluency with which unforeseen events enter *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* place it among simple plots. Aristotle further relates narrative material to fable, imagination and history; by that scheme this play belongs to the imaginative category. His tragic characters are renowned and noble, mixed in virtue and vice. Here too every character combines good and bad. Nibha is high-born yet becomes intimate with Ramani Mohan, who died from injuries inflicted

upon him after committing rape. The beggar woman is Anasuya, a Mithila painter. In contrast, the two respectable men, the city gentleman and four soldiers appear untainted. Bharata calls the lover of music and dance *dhīralalita*, the person of peaceful disposition *dhīrapraśānta*, the heroic or Kshatriya-like nature *dhīrodātta*, and the jealous or arrogant person *dhīroddhata*. The city gentleman and the two respectable men love music; Ramani Mohan becomes jealous at the sight of the lovers. The soldiers possess both tranquillity and heroic qualities and may be regarded as *dhīrapraśānta* and *dhīrodātta*. Yet no such division fully encompasses the characters of *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*.

Indian dramaturgy names five stages of action: *ārambha* (commencement), *prayatna* (effort), *prāptyāśā* (hope of attainment), *niyatāpti* (certainty of attainment), and *phalāgama* (fruition). At *prāptyāśā* disappointment threatens the outcome; at *niyatāpti* hope returns. Western theory describes exposition, rising action, climax, falling action and final resolution. The first three increase entanglement; the final two bring it to a close.

The five *arthaprakṛtis*, or elements of the developing action, are *bīja*, *bindu*, *patākā*, *prakarī* and *kārya*. In *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, the seed is the paradox of the world after death, especially an insurance agent who comes there without dying. Yama and Chitragupta eventually turn out to be actors in make-up. Various pivotal moments raise one character and lower another. *Patākā* and *prakarī* concern subsidiary episodes, which are absent here. *Kārya*, the fully developed seed, should be the completed action, yet here the action ends in a sit-in protest! Aristotle speaks of beginning, middle and end. Consider now the *sandhis*, or structural junctures: *mukha-sandhi* joins the seed and commencement; *pratimukha-sandhi* joins the connecting point and effort; *garbha-sandhi* joins the extended incident and hope of attainment; *vimarśa-sandhi* joins the brief episode and certainty of attainment; and *nirvahaṇa-sandhi* joins fruition and completed action. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* has *mukha*, *pratimukha* and *nirvahaṇa* junctures, but lacks the other two.

Western theory seeks the unities of place, time and action. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* takes place in a single location, unfolds in continuous time, and concerns one action: the desire to enter through the gate. A two-hour play depicts events lasting two hours. Abhinavagupta likewise advises that a single act should not contain events spanning more than a day and that two acts should not contain more than a year. The divisions into *kallolas* here arise from the time allotted to episodes and the interval before new action begins. Dryden, however, opposed the strict classical triad and defended the freedom of Shakespeare's plays. No such difficulty arises here.

Casual conversation among the characters—also describable as flashback —effectively reveals the circumstances of their deaths.

In India, the performability and visual nature of drama were supported, whereas Aristotle and Plato opposed spectacle in important respects. In the sixteenth century Lodovico Castelvetro argued for spectacle; d'Aubignac also supported the visual dimension, whereas Dryden emphasised drama's readability. Dacier valued both reading and performance. Abhinavagupta held that the fullest experience of *rasa* comes after performance, although reading can also yield aesthetic relish. At the opening of the first *kallola* of *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, the primacy of stage performance becomes clear. Western theatrical convention tends towards realistic representation; Indian theatre makes extensive use of symbolic gesture. For example, in *Abhijñānaśākuntalam* Kālidāsa writes, "He acts as though fitting an arrow to the bow." *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* adopts the Indian convention: the invisible wall of the gate to heaven is made perceptible by the characters' dialogue and acting. Performance was central to *Ankiyā Nāṭ* as well. *Kīrtaniyā* theatre was in one sense musical, yet acting played a dominant role there too; *Ankiyā* drama began with the sound of the *mṛdaṅga*. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* connects itself with Maithili tradition while offering a new perspective on history, mythology and contemporary life, and a fresh insight with which to think about them.

Extending the lineage of Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrtasamāgama*, Vidyapati's *Gorakṣavijaya*, *Kīrtaniyā* plays, *Ankiyā Nāṭ*, Munshi Raghunandan Das's *Mithila Nāṭak*, Jivan Jha's *Sundar Saṃyog*, Ishanath Jha's *Chīnīk Laḍḍū*, Govind Jha's *Basāt*, Manipadma's *Tesar Kaniyā*, Nachiketaji's "Nāyakak Nām Jīvan" and "Ek Chhal Rājā," Shreeji's *Puruṣārtha*, Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary's *Bhaphāit Chāhak Jīngī*, Mahendra Malangia's *Kāṭhak Lok*, Ram Bharos Kapari Bhramar's *Mahiṣāsur Murdābād*, and Gangesh Gunjan's *Budhibadhiyā*, Nachiketa's *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* repeatedly rejects the supposed objectivity of rationality and modernity. Yama even tells the leftist that what he sees may not be true at all, but a dream. The play thus comments on the supposed completeness of scientific knowledge. Everyone describes truth and falsehood from a particular point of view. The thief has his own argument, while the leftist says that thieves cannot become leaders, yet political leaders are threatening the thieves' livelihood by taking up theft themselves. Self-centred humour and judgements of good and bad arise and disappear repeatedly. Even Yama and Chitragupta live behind masks. Alongside these postmodern features, each character may reveal several identities, as does the high-born woman. No event has a single complete meaning, and one can never know when truth will turn into falsehood. The play abounds in superficial postmodern reflection and such characters. It offers neither optimism nor pessimism; what it offers is a kind of inspired madness, the idea that one thing may be

thought about in several different ways. Rather than place faith in results produced by reason, control and planning, it gives greater weight to the consequences of chance. Democratic and feminist outlooks and ideologies symbolised by the red flag also enter through laughter and satire.

Thus *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* presents a postmodern outlook. Readers encounter problems raised in the course of the plot which they recognise from their own lives. The conflict shown at the end does not astonish a reader in the postmodern age, for such conflicts are encountered in everyday life.

55. Four Postmodern Plays: Samuel Beckett's French *Waiting for Godot*, Harold Pinter's English *The Birthday Party*, Badal Sircar's Bengali *Evam Indrajit*, and Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s Maithili *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*

Abstract

[*No Entry: Mā Praviśa was published in 2008 and was not selected for the Sahitya Akademi Award in 2010, 2011 or 2012. It will therefore no longer be eligible for the Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili literature. The place of No Entry: Mā Praviśa between Maithili literature and world literature is examined below.*

Keywords: four postmodern plays; Samuel Beckett; French; *Waiting for Godot*

[*No Entry: Mā Praviśa* was published in 2008 and was not selected for the Sahitya Akademi Award in 2010, 2011 or 2012. It will therefore no longer be eligible for the Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili literature. There have been other instances of this kind. The position of *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* in relation to Maithili and world literature is examined below. This series will continue.]

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Waiting for Godot is a tragicomedy in two acts. Samuel Beckett wrote it in French in 1952; its first performance took place in Paris in 1953. The English version was staged in London in 1955 and published in 1956.

Harold Pinter's English play *The Birthday Party* was staged in Cambridge in 1958 and published in 1960.

Badal Sircar wrote the Bengali play *Evam Indrajit* in 1962, and it was staged in Calcutta in 1965.

Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* was published electronically in 2008 and also appeared in print that year. Directed by Kunal, the ninety-minute play was staged at Kalidas Rangalaya, Patna, on 19 February 2011.

All four plays—in French, English, Bengali and Maithili—are counted as postmodern drama. People leaving a performance of Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot* encountered a strange experience. There are only five characters: Estragon, Vladimir, Lucky, Pozzo and a boy. In the evening, on a country road beside a tree, Estragon sits on a mound of earth, struggling with both hands to take off his boots. He becomes exhausted. He and Vladimir begin to talk, wandering at length through trivial and

seemingly pointless exchanges. Pozzo and Lucky arrive. Pozzo appears to be the master, Lucky his slave—a slave with a long rope fixed around his neck by Pozzo. Lucky enters first, followed by Pozzo holding the rope. Lucky carries a large bag, folding stool, picnic basket and greatcoat. Pozzo has a whip, and Lucky obediently carries out every command, eventually standing again with the entire load. Estragon and Vladimir are uneasy at the sight of this burden. Pozzo says that Lucky is always like that, and Estragon takes Pozzo for a tyrant. When Estragon tries to wipe Lucky's tears, Lucky kicks him. Pozzo remarks that he had warned Estragon Lucky does not like strangers. What, meanwhile, are Estragon and Vladimir doing here? They are waiting for someone called Godot.

Pozzo and Lucky leave. A boy comes to Estragon and Vladimir and announces that Godot cannot come today but will come tomorrow. After further random chatter the boy departs. The stage lighting changes; night falls and the moon rises. Vladimir and Estragon resume their conversation, mixing occasional meaningful observations with apparently empty talk. They resolve to leave, yet neither moves. The curtain falls on Act I.

Act II takes place at the same time and in the same location. Vladimir remembers everything, but Estragon has forgotten. Estragon declares that he forgets everything instantly—or never forgets anything at all. Fragments of memory do come back to him. Pozzo and Lucky arrive. Pozzo is now blind, while Lucky carries his burdens as before. The rope remains, though shorter. Pozzo and Lucky fall to the ground. Pozzo cries for help, but Estragon and Vladimir continue talking.

As in the first act, Estragon calls Vladimir "Didi." Vladimir declares, "We must not waste time in idle chatter." Pozzo's cries for "Help!" come again and again at regular intervals, yet the pair pay no attention. Pozzo now offers first one hundred, then two hundred francs to anyone who helps him. Vladimir tries to lift him, falls himself in the attempt, and calls for help. Following further talk, Estragon tries to lift Vladimir and falls too. Vladimir strikes Pozzo, who groans. Vladimir then seeks him out, saying, "Come on, I shall not hurt you."

Estragon and Vladimir decide to try standing and manage to rise. Estragon says getting up is as easy as child's play; Vladimir calls it a question of willpower. Pozzo cries for help. They raise him, let go, and he falls. They raise him again and keep hold of him. After a while they release their grip experimentally, catching him whenever he begins to collapse. Pozzo too appears to have forgotten yesterday's events. He says he awoke one day and found himself blind, and wonders whether he may still be asleep. He asks about Lucky, apparently unable to remember how the two fell. Pozzo instructs them to pull hard on the rope around Lucky's neck or kick him in the face to wake him. Vladimir tells Estragon that this is an excellent

chance for revenge. Estragon asks—his memory is returning—what if Lucky defends himself? Pozzo assures him that Lucky never does. Estragon, or perhaps Vladimir, begins kicking Lucky but injures his own foot. By this point it seems that Pozzo has managed to stand unaided.

Pozzo is taking Lucky to sell him at a market, yet he remembers nothing of yesterday and will remember nothing tomorrow of today. He tells Lucky to get up. Lucky rises and lifts his baggage. Pozzo asks for his whip. Lucky puts down everything, hands over the whip, and picks up the baggage again. Pozzo asks for the rope. Lucky puts down all his burdens once more, hands the rope to Pozzo, and lifts the burdens again!

Lucky and Pozzo depart. The boy returns and addresses Vladimir as Albert. Vladimir asks if the boy does not recognise him and whether he was not here yesterday. The boy says this is his first visit. His message is unchanged: Godot will not come today but will certainly arrive tomorrow. Vladimir asks what Godot does; the boy replies that Godot does nothing. Vladimir asks after the boy's brother; he is unhappy, the boy says. Did his brother come yesterday? The boy does not know. The boy says that Godot has a beard and is fair rather than dark. As in the first act, he asks what message he should take back to Godot. Vladimir says, "Go and tell him that you met us." Vladimir rushes angrily towards the boy, who runs away. The sun sets and the moon appears.

Estragon suggests that separation might be better for both of them. Vladimir says that if Godot does not come tomorrow, they will hang themselves from a rope; if he comes, they will be saved. Vladimir looks into Lucky's hat, shakes it and puts it on. The two decide to leave but neither moves. The curtain falls.

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Harold Pinter's Three-Act Play *The Birthday Party*

Its characters are Petey, Meg, Stanley, Lulu, Goldberg and McCann.

Act I: Meg serves Petey breakfast and asks whether Stanley has got up. Stanley enters; Meg serves him breakfast too. Petey leaves for work. Meg and Stanley exchange intimate, joking remarks. Petey has told Meg that two visitors will come and stay in her house for several days. Her home is listed as a boarding house. Stanley, on hearing this, asks questions and becomes anxious. He says that he has received an offer to play piano in a Paris nightclub, followed by opportunities in Athens, Constantinople, Zagreb and Vladivostok: a job that would take him around the world. Asked about his experience, he claims to have played piano everywhere in the world, in every country, and to have given a concert once. He then says he lost the address of the first concert venue and could not reach it. When

he arrived at the second venue, it was locked. Meg does not want Stanley to leave.

Stanley suspects that the two men are looking for somebody. Lulu is heard outside. Meg leaves carrying a shopping bag; someone addresses her as Mrs Boles. Lulu enters and talks with Stanley. After Lulu leaves, Goldberg and McCann arrive. McCann calls Goldberg "Nat." Stanley has already slipped away. Meg returns. Goldberg addresses her as Mrs Boles and introduces himself and his friend McCann. During their conversation he asks about the other lodger, his name and occupation. Meg says he is Stanley Webber, who once gave a concert but, owing to the caretaker's mistake, was locked inside the venue all night until morning. He then took his "tip," caught a train and came here. Suddenly Meg says that today is Stanley's birthday. A birthday party is planned for nine o'clock, and Lulu is to be invited that afternoon. All three go out, and Stanley looks through the window. Meg returns. Stanley is suspicious of the two strangers. He asks their names; Meg has forgotten but remembers "Gold..." and Stanley supplies "Goldberg." Meg asks whether Stanley knows him, but Stanley remains silent. He then says that today is not his birthday. Meg has bought him a child's drum as a present and demands a kiss in return.

Act II: Stanley and McCann are talking. Stanley wants to go out. He tells McCann that this is not a boarding house and never has been. Petey and Goldberg arrive. Goldberg addresses Petey as Mr Boles. After Petey leaves, Stanley says that the people of this house have lost their sense of smell and cannot recognise the danger posed by Goldberg and McCann. He feels responsible for them.

McCann snatches Stanley's spectacles. McCann and Goldberg demand to know why he murdered his wife. They accuse him of changing his name, lacking moral character and corrupting women.

An argument breaks out. When it has ended, Meg—apparently unaware of it—enters in her party dress. Ordinary conversation follows.

Lulu arrives and Goldberg seats her upon his lap. When Lulu asks why she thought his name was Nat, Goldberg explains that his wife calls him "Simey."

At the party they begin playing a game of blindman's buff. Lulu ties a scarf over Mrs Boles's eyes. Whoever Meg touches next must then be blindfolded. She touches McCann, and the turn later falls to Stanley. His spectacles are taken away, and a blindfold is placed over his eyes. McCann breaks Stanley's spectacles and sets the drum in his path. Stanley falls and tries to throttle Meg, but McCann and Goldberg save her.

Darkness falls.

Seeing Stanley approach, Lulu faints. Stanley places Lulu upon a table. McCann finds a torch and shines it upon the table and Stanley.

Act III: Petey and Meg talk, and Meg asks him about Stanley. Lulu enters and asks Goldberg what her father or Eddie, her first lover, would think if he heard what had happened. She accuses Goldberg of satisfying his wicked thirst and teaching her what a young woman would otherwise learn only after being married three times. Goldberg answers that he did it because Lulu allowed him to.

Lulu leaves.

In Meg's absence Goldberg and McCann take Stanley away. Petey tells them to leave Stanley alone. Goldberg and McCann invite Petey to come with them too: there is room in the car. Petey stands still. Left alone, he is joined by Meg. "Have they gone?" she asks. "Yes," he says. "Is Stanley still asleep?" she asks. Petey answers that he is sleeping.

"Let him sleep."

Meg asks, "Wasn't it a good party?" Petey says, "He came later."

The curtain falls.

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Badal Sircar's *Evam Indrajit*

The characters in *Evam Indrajit* are the Writer, the Aunt, Manasi, Amal, Vimal, Kamal, Indrajit and, later in the play, Indrajit's wife, another Manasi.

Act I: The Writer is searching for a play. His aunt is angry that he goes on writing instead of eating and drinking properly. Manasi asks whether he will read what he has written. The Writer says he has written nothing. She urges him to try. The Writer calls four latecomers from the auditorium to the stage: Amal, Vimal and Kamal. The fourth calls himself Nirmal Kumar. The Writer objects that this is impossible and asks his real name. "Indrajit Ray," he replies. Amal, Vimal, Kamal—and Indrajit. Manasi—her actual name is different, but the Writer calls her Manasi—is Indrajit's maternal cousin. He loves her and wants to break with convention.

Act II: Later Indrajit wonders whether a successful love affair would answer his questions. It would not. He will go to London too. He wants death but cannot bring himself to die. The Woman whom the Writer calls Manasi, the one associated with Indrajit, remains unmarried and teaches in Hazaribagh.

Unlike Amal, Vimal and Kamal, Indrajit refuses to follow the beaten track. He wants something different. The aunt, whom the Writer calls

"mother," tells him to eat; Manasi tells him to write. But when Manasi also tells the Writer to eat, he is hurt: "No—not you too!"

Manasi then realises her mistake and asks about his writing. The Writer is disturbed: this Indrajit refuses to acknowledge reality and shows no commitment to anything. Manasi disagrees.

"But he does dream, doesn't he?"

Indrajit returns to Calcutta from London and marries another woman, also called Manasi—Indrajit calls her Manasi. The first Manasi, whom the Writer names Manasi, is Indrajit's maternal cousin. He loves her but does not marry her because she is regarded as his sister and because of what people will say; all along he insists to the Writer that her name is not Manasi.

Indrajit begins to understand, and tells Manasi, that differences among individuals are merely an illusion. A dream is a dream and cannot become reality. Manasi, Manasi, Manasi—all are Manasi, just as there are Amal, Vimal and Kamal. When the Writer asks him, Indrajit replies: "Amal, Vimal, Kamal—and Indrajit as well!"

The Writer's journey has no destination and no purpose: an apparently meaningless journey with no reason behind it. He tells Indrajit that we must live and keep walking; there is no sacred destination, yet the pilgrimage must continue.

Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*

The Plot—First *Kallola*: This play is divided into *kallolas* in the tradition of Jyotirishwar. His *Varṇaratnākara* is divided into *kallolas*, although it is not a play, whereas his play *Dhūrtasamāgama* is divided into acts. The first of four *kallolas* opens at the gate of heaven—or hell—where a large number of the deceased are queuing to enter. There is a city gentleman who died in a road accident, along with soldiers killed in war, thieves killed while stealing, rogues and pickpockets. The ultramodern absurdity of Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrtasamāgama* is evident also in *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*. In the first *kallola*, when a thief and a ruffian break the queue and go forward, the city gentleman seizes each of them by the collar and returns them to their places. The ruffian, later revealed as a gang boss, tells him to let go of his shirt, but is momentarily restrained by the gentleman's imposing manner. When a pickpocket speaks from the gentleman's side against the thief, the ruffian draws a knife, reveals his true nature and launches himself at the pickpocket. The thief explains that the pickpocket belongs to their own fraternity but has only managed to become a petty pickpocket, not a skilled thief like himself, and could never even dream of being a hardened thug like the ruffian. The ruffian

now turns on the thief: whom did he just call a thug? The pickpocket quickly changes sides and tells the ruffian that the insult was aimed at him, not at the ruffian. He adds that the thief is so incompetent at his craft that a householder's sons and dogs beat him to death while he was stealing—and yet he dares ridicule a pickpocket and call himself a great thief! The respectable man cannot believe that someone who speaks so fluently could actually be a thief, so the pickpocket teases "His Majesty the Thief" still further. The thief then laments that, had he known, he would never have taken this pickpocket along to steal that night, nor would he have been able to bear seeing him beaten. The city gentleman, who earlier dragged the thief and ruffian back by their collars, listens in silence and wonders what sort of heaven it will be if he must live there with such people. He recites a fragment of song upon the subject. As in *Dhūrtasamāgama*, songs are interspersed throughout *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*; the singing begins here and makes this a musical play. Meanwhile the pickpocket empties everyone's pockets and wallets. Another musical refrain begins, but a dead ragpicker interrupts the spell by observing that beyond the closed gate of Yama's realm, money and purses are of no use. The two deceased respectable men agree: the currency of one country is not accepted in another. A dead romantic gentleman named Ramani Mohan comments that changing countries' currencies is much like one's beloved becoming someone else's wife. An argument begins, so Ramani Mohan changes the subject to the Apsaras Rambha and Menaka who may be waiting inside. A beggar woman, who has passed the doll she was cradling to someone else in order to join the argument, jealously abuses Rambha and Menaka as sharp-tongued women. The pickpocket points out that the other side may contain sorrow as readily as happiness. This delights an insurance agent, who sees an opportunity to expand his business. The pickpocket then begins soliciting bids, in rupees, for Indra's thunderbolt. The city gentleman interrupts the proceedings, and the respectable men support him: what an extraordinary auction, run by a pickpocket with the thief and beggar woman bidding! They have never heard of its like. Another musical refrain starts. Just then Nandi and Bhringi enter, dancing to classical music. Asked by Nandi and Bhringi what lies beyond the door, each character answers according to his or her beliefs: heaven or hell, the heights of the sky or the depths below. Nandi and Bhringi tell them that each has spoken the truth, yet none has spoken the whole truth. They begin listing the deaths: one was killed while stealing (at which the thief tries to run away, only to be brought back by two or three others), one in an accident, and so on. But even Nandi and Bhringi cannot explain how the insurance agent arrived here without dying. He declares that he has come prospecting for a new market! Thus one person is present without being dead. Bhringi explains to Nandi the fierce competition brought about by the arrival of so many insurance companies. Meanwhile the lovers

quarrel because the young man wants to go back. Ramani Mohan is delighted at the prospect of the young man's departure: the woman will be alone and he will have his chance. Bhringi says that leaving this place is impossible, though the couple might go and arrange for their respective parents to die in accidents and join them. The lovers refuse to sacrifice their parents for their own convenience. Nandi and Bhringi therefore marry the pair with music and ceremonial instruments, the city gentleman performing the giving away of the bride.

Postmodern, Emotion-Centred Absurd Drama: Samuel Beckett himself translated *En attendant Godot* from French into English as *Waiting for Godot*, adding the subtitle "A Tragicomedy in Two Acts," which was absent from the French edition. A tragicomedy combines tragedy and comedy. The foregoing account of the plot should have made clear that its supposed central character, "Godot," does not appear at all. Nor is he its emotional centre. Its essential element is *waiting*. Language, the stage, speech, silence and ways of moving form inseparable parts of the work. Its main characters live like wandering nomads moving through space and time. They perform like mime artists, conveying emotion through the body without speaking. The play gives new definitions to plot and dramatic equilibrium and ushers modern theatre into a new age. British music-hall theatre combined music and comedy; Beckett uses cross-talk to dramatise the despair of life, while Harold Pinter represents political and social terror through humour. *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* also begins at the entrance to heaven—or hell—where the people queueing are all dead, except for one living person! The ruffian becomes submissive before the city gentleman! The lovers even marry there! Netaji is fated to arrive late after death! The leftist still lends outside support! There is no escaping a VIP queue even there! Chitragupta, however, reveals that the door before which they queue used to open and close in another age. If it no longer opens, what are they waiting for? Nandi and Bhringi say that the apparent door was not a dream but a mistake in understanding. When the actor Vivek Kumar is asked his surname, he says that he has left caste behind only after a tremendous struggle, so let the "alias" be dropped. The leftist believes in neither heaven nor hell, neither Yama nor Chitragupta; yet how can he disbelieve what he sees here? Yama himself tells him that it may be a nightmare. Yama's messengers stand beside their cauldrons with nobody to roast. When the beggar woman laughs at Chitragupta's make-up beard, Bhringi says that she too is an artist like them. And how can the door of the mind be opened if the mind itself has been left behind?

The four plays—Beckett's French *Waiting for Godot*, Pinter's English *The Birthday Party*, Sircar's Bengali *Evam Indrajit*, and Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s Maithili *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*—fall outside the defined beginnings and endings of conventional drama. They begin anywhere and end anywhere. In *Evam Indrajit*, the Writer searches for characters and suddenly addresses the auditorium, summons four latecomers onstage and makes them characters in the play. The fourth is his favourite: not Nirmal but Indrajit, someone different, a figure bearing the historical name of one who conquered Indra. He will not follow the line taken by Amal,

Vimal and Kamal. Yet by the end he too becomes part of the refrain: Amal, Vimal, Kamal—and Indrajit.

The early criticism of Harold Pinter's *The Birthday Party* was so severe that his literary career nearly ended. Its rereading, however, made it a classic. Pinter sustains a measure of mystery and terror throughout the play, and humour strengthens the dramatic substance. What is Stanley, what was he, and what does he want to become? Does he corrupt women, or did he murder his wife? Why does Meg like him? What prevented his first and second concerts? Is he lying, or does he behave outside existing social and political categories? He tries to strangle Meg, yet why does she continue to like him? Why and how do social and political powers carry him away, represented by Goldberg and McCann, even though Goldberg's mysterious behaviour towards Lulu shows that the supposed agents of authority cannot themselves embody any ideal?

A mound of earth and a leafless, naked tree by a desolate road make the stage for *Waiting for Godot*. The space outside a locked gate provides the stage for *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*. In *Evam Indrajit* the audience itself becomes the stage. In *The Birthday Party* the stage is a room in a house, yet Pinter seems to take Stanley apart and put him together again by a process resembling Derrida's deconstruction. Spectators alternately envy him, sympathise with him and despise him. But when he appears powerless before Goldberg and McCann, they identify with him, just as they identify with Indrajit in *Evam Indrajit*. In *Waiting for Godot*, the spectator identifies with the slave, only to be startled when an offer of compassion earns a kick. In *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*, the beggar woman jealously abuses Rambha and Menaka! The pickpocket puts Indra's thunderbolt up for auction in exchange for rupees. Nandi and Bhringi declare that everyone has spoken truth, yet nobody the complete truth. Indrajit in *Evam Indrajit* resembles Sisyphus, the accursed figure of Greek myth condemned to push a marble boulder uphill; whenever he reaches the summit, it rolls back down and carries him to the foot. Human labour and life are founded upon absurdity. Is humanity condemned to fail, like Indrajit? Or will the sight of heaven and hell, Yama and Chitragupta being exposed as false in *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* change what we think we have seen? But then Yama himself says the apparent reality may be a nightmare. *Waiting for Godot* is not about waiting for God: Beckett himself says they are waiting not for "God" but for "Godot," even though he uses Christian mythology. In existentialist thought, humanity and the universe are meaningless, absurd.

56. *Chhutahar*, *Chhutahar Ghail*, or *Chhuthā Ghail*

Abstract

Chhutahar / Chhutahar Ghail / Chhuthā Ghail: Chhuthā Ghail is the title of Mahendra Malangia's latest play. He has written a ten-page preface to this short drama. He is distressed that Ramanand Jha "Raman" suggested that a "chhutahar ghail" is called simply a "chhutahar."

Keywords: *chhutahar*; *ghail*; *chhuthā*; literary criticism; Maithili

Chhutahar / Chhutahar Ghail / Chhuthā Ghail: *Chhuthā Ghail* is the name of Mahendra Malangia's latest play. To this small play he has attached a ten-page preface. Let us first consider that preface. Malangia resents Ramanand Jha "Raman" for advising him that a *chhutahar ghail* is called simply *chhutahar*. He offers three arguments. First, he invokes the lines, "You may speak of what is written in books; / I shall speak of what these eyes have seen." Second, he cites Yatri's lament: "I remain apart, like a *ghail chhutahar*; / Alas, how wretched is my great misfortune." And he asks what the widow in Yatri's poem or Kabutari Devi in his play has to do with Shiva's *Māheśvara Sūtras* or Pāṇini's ten *lakāras* (Pāṇini identified twelve such verbal formations for Vedic Sanskrit and ten for Classical Sanskrit—but let that pass). Third, he likens his own position to that of Copernicus: what can the objections of other people matter, when people in villages and homes do in fact say *chhutahar ghail*! Yet all three arguments turn against Malangia himself. "What these eyes have seen" and actual usage establish that the object is called *chhutahar* alone. Can one place a *chhutahar* atop a *ghailchī*? When water is sprinkled in the courtyard from a *loiṭā*, should it, according to Malangia's logic, be called a *loiṭā ghail*? *Ghail*, *surāhī*, *kohā*, *taulā*, *chhutahar*, *loiṭā*, *khāpaṛi*, *kuṛnī*, *kurvār*, *kosiyā*, *sarbā* and *sobarnā* are the distinct names of distinct objects. Accepting the suggestion of Phoolchandra Mishra "Raman"—who probably proposed *chhuthā ghail* in jest, and, if not, has coined a new word for the language—Malangia changed *chhutahar ghail* to *chhuthā ghail*. This shows that he had realised his mistake, but did not wish to appear diminished by agreeing with Ramanand Jha "Raman"; instead, he planted his own stake. Later Ramanand Jha "Raman" urged Chetna Samiti to publish the book, but because that institution would give him only twenty-five copies, Malangia published it through his own organisation. What concern are these details of the reader's? Now consider Yatri. Yatri had Hindi readers to think of as well, and often did not remember which of his poems were in Hindi, which in Maithili and which in both languages. He wrote *chhutahar ghail*, perhaps because of the demands of rhyme. Now consider Copernicus. If Yatri or Malangia writes *ghail chhutahar*, *chhutahar ghail* or *chhuthā ghail*, will native Maithili

speakers suddenly begin using those expressions instead of *chhutahar*? Thus Copernicus too stands against Malangia's position. Malangia cannot deploy the Copernican legend accurately. He may even be confusing Copernicus with Galileo: Copernicus's theory received papal support, and he dedicated the forty-page manuscript of his heliocentric theory to Pope Paul III. In any case, one will not be surprised by Malangia's ignorance of science or his tendency to turn scientific theory into legend after encountering in the same preface his ignorance of well-known folktales. "Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves" is known worldwide as a medieval Arabic folktale found in *The Arabian Nights* or *One Thousand and One Nights*. There is debate as to whether it was inserted later into that collection, but its status as a medieval Arabic folktale is not in dispute. Malangia brings in tales of Balban's tyranny and other claims with a communal outlook, exposing only his superficial acquaintance with folklore. The shallow understanding of *pañjī* genealogy represented by *Mithilā Tattva Vimarśa* or Ramanath Jha was overcome long ago; the relevant information is recorded in our genealogy books. Gonu Jha lived three hundred years before Vidyapati, but Malangia proceeds upon fifty-year-old gossip. He knows that Gonu has been called *Dhūrtācārya*, a master of cunning, but apparently does not know that Gonu is also called *Mahāmahopādhyāya*. Muslims did not live in Mithila in Gonu Jha's period; where, then, could the story of "the tax collector's beard" have come from as a Muslim official's beard? An object known to the people as *chhutahar* is turned into *chhuthā ghail*. The beard of a man who collected taxes becomes the beard of a *tahsildār*, allowing Muslims to be cast as oppressors on communal grounds. And the preface is written in such a way, it seems, that Ramanand Jha "Raman" and others will be intimidated into silence. The Satnami rebellion, begun with a quarrel between a foot-soldier and a member of the progressive Satnami community founded by Dalit and backward groups, arose in resistance to Aurangzeb's policies, and a mosque was burned during it. But Gonu Jha's tax collector was not Muslim; the folktale makes no such claim. If a communally minded folklorist introduces his own ideology into a transmitted story and writes it down dishonestly, what has that to do with Maithili folklore? This is what happens when folktales are collected without fieldwork. Mahendra Narayan Ram writes that folklore knows no caste distinctions, but how could Malangia accept that? A *bhagatā*, too, inevitably appears in his narrative. The real cause that makes this habit integral to Malangia's theatre is his inherited belief in caste superiority. His play consists of seventeen scenes averaging two and a half pages apiece. Up to the fifteenth scene he follows his familiar method of making high-caste audiences laugh at the purported speech of the "lower castes" (a language of his own invention) and generating counterfeit comedy through the *bhagatā*'s corrupted Hindi. He begins trying to give the story a purpose only in the

sixteenth scene, by which time the opportunity has been lost. At a time when Prakrit and other languages are no longer used in Sanskrit plays as they once were, Malangia's invocation of Bharata out of context reveals his lack of command of Sanskrit and suggests reliance on Hindi-language secondary accounts of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. Is Malangia claiming that a play good to read cannot be staged, or that one written for the stage cannot be good to read? That is what his Sanskrit quotations seem to imply. If a play does not stir a reader, how will a director decide to stage it? And what, precisely, are its stage qualities: seventeen scenes of about two and a half pages each, casteist language that humiliates a supposedly inferior class, the *bhagatā*'s Hindi "*Samajhtā hai ki nahī?*" ("Do you understand or not?"), and the slapstick humour supposedly produced by bringing these together? Whoever resists this and imagines a parallel Maithili theatre is dismissed as merely advocating the readability of drama, while an old-fashioned casteist is praised as a defender of its stage qualities! Would Malangia's caste-based sentence constructions be accepted in twenty-first-century plays in Sanskrit, Hindi or any other modern Indian language apart from Maithili? If not, why does a playwright who has not read Bharata's original Sanskrit *Nāṭyaśāstra* repeatedly deploy decontextualised details from eighteen-hundred-year-old Sanskrit drama as a shield for his vocabulary? If someone carries a basket on the head and a child on the hip, must that person belong to a lower class? In the *bārahmāsā* in his courtyard, Malangia calls women of this class *rāṇḍ*. After several decades, he has improved to the extent of calling them a "lower class." That improvement is welcome, but it is much too little for so long a period. How did Babaji enter the story, and how did *gāñjā* enter it? What have they to do with the trees in the orchard? How could Malangia have inserted his caste-based constructions and corrupted Hindi sentences had he not created the pseudo-concepts of the *bhagatā* and a lower class? He tries very cleverly to conceal this fact and therefore cannot move beyond mediocrity. He wants to give this dramatic narrative a purpose, but he cannot acquire the ability to do so.

57. Four English Plays—*Doctor Faustus*, *Samson Agonistes*, *Murder in the Cathedral*, and *Strife*

Abstract

This essay is based upon Parshuram Jha's Dimensions of Peace in English Drama: Studies in Doctor Faustus, Samson Agonistes, Murder in the Cathedral and Strife. Parshuram Jha (born 1938), from Mehath village in Madhubani, is the author of Dimensions of Peace in English Drama and Christian Poetic Drama.

Keywords: four English plays; *Doctor Faustus*; *Samson Agonistes*; *Murder in the Cathedral*; *Strife*

This essay is based upon Parshuram Jha's *Dimensions of Peace in English Drama: Studies in Doctor Faustus, Samson Agonistes, Murder in the Cathedral and Strife*. Parshuram Jha, born in 1938 in Mehath village, Madhubani, wrote *Dimensions of Peace in English Drama* and *Christian Poetic Drama*. He devoted his entire professional life to teaching English literature.

Doctor Faustus belongs to the Elizabethan age, *Samson Agonistes* to the Age of Reason, and *Murder in the Cathedral* to the modern age. These three are essentially religious dramas. *Strife* is a modern secular play and demonstrates, in this reading, that secularism emerges from religion, or at least from the moral context of religion.

Doctor Faustus (*The Tragical History of the Life and Death of Doctor Faustus*) was written by Christopher Marlowe (1564–1593), a contemporary of Shakespeare (1564–1616). The Privy Council issued a warrant summoning Marlowe in connection with an objectionable manuscript, and ten days later he was stabbed to death at the age of twenty-nine. Whether he might have surpassed Shakespeare as a dramatist had he lived a full life remains hidden in history. The play mixes blank verse and prose. Blank verse has metre but no rhyme. It was performed in Marlowe's lifetime but published eleven years after his death.

Samson Agonistes ("Samson the Wrestler" or "Samson the Combatant") is a tragic closet drama in verse by John Milton (1608–1674). A closet drama is written not primarily for staging but for solitary reading, or to be read aloud and heard by a small group.

Murder in the Cathedral is a verse drama by T. S. Eliot (1564–1593).

Strife, a play about bitter industrial conflict, was written by John Galsworthy (1867–1933).

Doctor Faustus — Christopher Marlowe

In 1592, *Doctor Faustus* was constructed through additions to and omissions from the *English Faust Book*, presenting the realities of its age.

In both subject and form, *Doctor Faustus* is connected with the medieval mystery play, the morality play and the interlude. Yet Faustus's uncontrollable thirst for limitless knowledge, worldly pleasure and power brings it close to the spirit of the Renaissance.

When Faustus first enters, two choices face him: the spiritual or the worldly life; unending enjoyment or a spiritual abyss and death; the pursuit of his own will or obedience to God's will. He is learned, having studied Aristotle's logic; he knows medicine and the treatment of disease, and holds a doctorate in theology. Yet none of this learning gives him peace or joy. He chooses magic and the satisfaction of worldly desire.

In choosing magic he abandons his reliance on faith.

Faustus covets the gold of the West Indies and America (called India in Marlowe's day), pearls of the East, and fine fruits. Valdes and Cornelius are the magicians who offer a means to satisfy his desires.

Later Mephistophilis appears. Faustus asks him to tell Lucifer that he is ready to exchange his soul for worldly pleasures. The Good Angel advises Faustus to think of heaven and heavenly things, but Faustus follows the Evil Angel and desires wealth.

Faustus writes the deed mortgaging his soul in his own blood and surrenders himself to Lucifer. Mephistophilis tells him of hell, but he pays no attention, turning instead to sleep, food and travel. With Mephistophilis's help, Faustus gains opportunities for disputation, the accumulation of knowledge, astronomy, botany and aesthetics.

Before satisfying Faustus's sexual desires, Mephistophilis tries to reason with him, but then dresses an evil spirit as a woman and presents her as Faustus's wife.

An evil spirit may imitate a dead person but cannot itself come to life. Its kiss therefore sucks the very soul from Faustus. Through his intercourse with the evil spirit he commits sin, the consequence of which is his spiritual death.

He moves away from God and immerses himself in revelry, to spend twenty-four years in the company of the evil spirit.

As the time fixed in the bond for his death approaches, he says, "Had I lived with them, I would have lived a settled life; but now, in dying, I shall die forever."

And in his final moments, before his death, the clock ticks towards midnight. In despair he says, "His soul must yet live on to dwell in hell." But...

He tells the scholars that the serpent which tempted Eve may be saved, but Faustus cannot.

He cannot repent, cannot be forgiven or sanctified. He admits that he has insulted God.

Samson Agonistes — John Milton

The opening shows Samson, blinded and imprisoned at Gaza, forced into hard labour, being led by someone towards a bright place outside the prison. It is a holiday, the festival of Dagon, the Philistine god imagined as half-human and half-fish. Feeling the breeze, Samson experiences a resurgence of energy. He possesses power given by heaven to free Israel from Philistine subjugation. Yet he thinks that God gave him immense strength without equal wisdom; otherwise he would not have revealed its secret so readily to Delilah. But how can he dispute the wisdom and wishes of God?

His father Manoa brings a plan for his release. Manoa proposes paying the Philistine lords to secure Samson's freedom, but Samson dislikes the proposal and refuses.

Manoa tells him that during the feast the Philistines will praise Dagon and insult the God of Israel. Samson is distressed by this news. He assures Manoa that he has no doubt Israel's God will prevail over Dagon. Yet after Manoa has left, he asks the chorus how he will be able to serve God.

Delilah enters and promises to persuade the Philistine lords to free him, but Samson denounces her for revealing his secret.

Harapha tells Samson that God has abandoned him.

An official arrives with an order from the Philistine lords that Samson must display his feats at Dagon's feast. At first he refuses, then reflects and agrees. Milton depicts the Philistines as steeped in worldly pleasure and Dagon as the god of that pleasure. Samson stands between two pillars, prays, and brings the building down.

The messenger's account produces a calm reaction from Samson's father. He says this is no time for grief: by his death Samson has brought honour and freedom to Israel.

Murder in the Cathedral — T. S. Eliot

Murder in the Cathedral begins with a chorus of women of Canterbury describing a world of nature neither kindly nor safe.

A messenger announces that the Archbishop is returning to England. Becket has spent seven years in France and now comes back to Canterbury. Both external and internal conflicts await him: the conflict of state and church, king and archbishop, but also a struggle with his own desires. He calls his past, including his friendship with the barons and his chancellorship, a "shadow" with which he must contend.

Four knights, his external enemies, enter brandishing swords. Becket has already conquered his enemy within and calmly tells the knights, "You are welcome, whatever your purpose."

He says that he has never wished to take the crown away from the king's son.

When the knights convey the king's order that he leave the country, Becket refuses: he has already spent seven years apart from his people.

Before they kill him, he tells the knights, "Do with me what you will, but my people will not so much as touch you."

Against his wishes the priests force him inside the cathedral and lock the church doors. Becket, however, says:

> "The church must always remain open, even to enemies."

As soon as the doors are opened, the drunken knights enter, intent upon murdering Becket.

Becket is killed, and the priests thank God for giving Canterbury another saint.

Strife — John Galsworthy

An industrial dispute at the Trenartha Tin Plate Works has led to a strike beginning in October. Four months later, on 7 February, a special board meeting is held in the dining room of the manager, Francis Underwood, who is the son-in-law of company chairman John Anthony. The directors Frederick H. Wilder, William Scantlebury and Oliver Wanklin are present, along with Anthony's younger son Edgar.

Edgar is distressed by the workers' plight. Wilder, however, is furious that the company's shares have fallen and worried about losses exceeding fifty thousand pounds. Scantlebury favours nonviolence, while Wanklin adopts a middle course.

Anthony, on the other hand, is opposed to showing any sympathy for the workers.

Wilder suggests asking Harness of the Central Union to help resolve the dispute, but Anthony refuses.

Roberts attends with other members of the workers' committee and opposes Anthony. Unlike Harness, he too is uncompromising.

Anthony's daughter Enid objects to her father's class prejudice. Her maid Annie is married to Roberts, and Enid wishes to help her. Enid visits Roberts in his cottage and urges a compromise. Roberts calls Anthony a tyrant and declares that if Anthony were dying and could be saved by the mere lifting of Roberts's hand, he would not raise even his little finger.

At a workers' meeting Evans and John Bulgin, supporters of Roberts, quarrel. Henry Thomas intervenes and says, "Shame on your strife!"

At the afternoon meeting he announces Mrs Roberts's death and says that he will resign his membership.

Anthony, however, declares, "War is war."

Roberts arrives a little late at the board meeting and discovers that the workers have removed him. Meanwhile Anthony has been displaced by his own directors.

Negotiations towards a settlement proceed under Harness's leadership. Henry Tench, the company secretary, is satisfied.

58. Nachiketa's "Second Person Singular"

Abstract

Poetry differs from prose in that images allow it to say more in fewer words. It is therefore not possible to regard verse as a substitute for prose adopted because the writer is short of time, although examples of that sort can indeed be found. Whether verse follows metre or dispenses with metre and rhythm, genuine quality will make its impact felt.

Keywords: Nachiketa · second person · singular · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · सारांश

This chapter presents a fieldwork-based study in folk culture of Nachiketa's "Second Person Singular". The discussion brings Nachiketa, the second person, the singular, "my" and poetry to the fore. Drawing upon examples, quotations and arguments available in the original material, it comparatively examines fieldwork, oral sources and textual forms, enabling readers to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

Poetry differs from prose in that images allow it to say more in fewer words. It is therefore not possible to regard verse as a substitute for prose adopted because the writer is short of time, although examples of that sort can indeed be found. Whether verse follows metre or dispenses with metre and rhythm, genuine quality will make its impact felt. People invoke the political left or right to save land from the ceiling laws. But to invoke the left or the right on behalf of literature that has fallen under a ceiling, or to insist upon—or reject—metre and rhythm, is merely to extend the manoeuvring of literary factions. Amid all this stands Nachiketa's collection of thirty-three poems, *Madhyamapurush Ekavachan* (*Second Person Singular*).

In "Virodh Samudra Se" ("Against the Sea"), the poet speaks of the sea lying between you and me: somebody is weeping on its shore, over its consequences; between us are fish and flocks of kites, while Varuna holds the crests of all the tides, wondering whether to let love win or the sea. When the poet says that he will once again take hold of the crest of Varuna's tide, a picture rises before the eyes. In "Ritu-vishesh Prithvi Par" ("A Particular Season on Earth"), there is the particular season of love, at whose outset even the drops of the rainy month begin to dry. A net is cast for words, and words surrender in the poem's renunciation. Then the poet returns to the riverbank, to utter a morning mantra that turns water into sky. The god of rain in a barren country can make even the sky weep beyond measure. Ghosts dance, striking their sticks again and again; a young prince dreams of communism and releases balloons into the sky. There is a compromise with words, and every sigh is submerged in their

scream. Then comes a summons to the sky: weep aloud, so that the sound of lightning may convince us that Sawan has come to earth. There is the desire to touch the drops falling from the forehead and to read one's own written lines: the task the poet left unfinished the last time. This, precisely, is the particular season—to remember that person.

In "Toñ" ("You"), one enters a sentence hesitantly, holds a heated hand, and encounters the fire raging within me: in it are I and you, a branch of the wish-fulfilling tree; all else is empty, like some grandmother's tale. The ten directions ripen within it—an illusory path (bewildered!). The long hours of nine months of pride, of pregnancy. A fifth season (!), a sixth enemy (!); even the raga is in vilambit, the slow tempo, then drut, the fast beat (frightened), and the sun goes down. In "Ratuk Aa Dink Katha" ("A Tale of Night and Day"), the Buddha leaves home while the world sleeps, but the poet's departure takes place inside the poem, beyond the legally contracted ceremony of marriage and the pain of childbirth. Within the poem are loosened knots without metre or letter, stitching pulled open, needlework, points falling into the innermost being; a dirty, coarse towel tries to cover my body, while instability grows inside. Then come hunger and the story of pain and separation. Sexuality spreads over everything as it stands erect, becoming the dense array of all thirty-six dishes in your kitchen. Yet my "saka"—the poet's own abbreviated or equivocal expression—seeks only the poem's interior. Its sense is double; its subtle argument has melted into beat and rhythm. A body is packed with Prakrit and liver, weighted with awareness of the great womb and phallus. This is the only expedient learnt: to keep dreaming of you at every instant. When the world awakens, I shall sleep beside you. O my poem, the night of destruction will come; remove pain, separation, hunger and fear. Already a ray of dawn glimmers, like hope born of longing.

In "Chakrant" ("Conspiracy"), the temper of letters floating in the sky sends forth a bitter surge of fire; it will not be the poet's fault if that fire is extinguished. The world's cycle comes to an end. There is no hope that she will come to him, nor that his poetry, transformed into words, will dress itself for another shower of rain as before. In "Damayanti Ke Upadesh" ("Advice to Damayanti"), people stand petrified (!) on the riverbank—limbless, helpless people. Grass and leaves envelop them, and a Takshaka serpent is tangled among the silk-cotton trees. There is swaying in the wind and the smouldering of a fire fanned into flame. "Damayanti, Damayanti": the forest is mute. Amid flowers and leaves stands an orphaned sun (!), staggering as it carefully cuts open Hiranyaka's belly. Thirty-three ugly mouths counsel the trees to go this way. "Damayanti, do not cross the forest." In the darkness, traffickers in human bodies wait in the north-east. "Damayanti, it is time." Nala, the godlike husband, hides in the south-west. To know trees is to know how a poem arrives; it is to

learn the history of the forest and the cruelty of human beings—how the vast woodland was thoughtlessly devastated, uprooted and destroyed, and how domesticated (!) trees forgot their language. Damayanti is warned not to trust human beings: they will bind her with stories, poems and rumours. She must not cross the forest. And then every tree will write its first poem about Damayanti.

In "Prashnavali" ("Questionnaire") the questions come in succession: Is this the last immovable night? Is this the last line of the song? Can you read my poem? Is this my last day? Now there is the compulsion (!) to act, the body bewildered: what poverty, felt in that instant, is this? Have I merely been sleeping and enduring? What future awaits my letters? The restless bee of the mind ranges over an immense landscape like an undying current of love. In "Bheetar Ugait Shabd" ("Words Growing Within"), the sounds of words suggest somebody weeping in a cave, or laughter ringing from a mountain summit. There is the sound of furtive footsteps and of an envelope being opened; words seethe from every line of a letter. Only belatedly does one comprehend the tears running down a sister's face. Sentences drift away, refusing to become either a remainder or a compound; it is difficult to understand the creaking of a broken spine, yet it grips the stiffened poet by the throat and drags him forward. In the poem these words reappear as intimations of things heard, sensed and understood. They have emerged from within the poet, but even the poet has no authority to alter them. He has only the right to kiss them, to love and unite with them; not the right to churn them endlessly or to exercise hatred and anger. He may adorn them with flowers and leaves, braid the hours of the night into their hair, brighten the parting of that hair with the red of the first sunrise, place a garland of night-flowering jasmine about the neck, wrap their bodies in the warm bark of a tree: all this honours the fact of their having happened as words. The poet dedicates this poem to the poet Ila Rani Singh.

In "Janal-Pahichanal" ("Known and Familiar"), the body is read page after page until life itself begins to seem known and familiar. There are songs of depths and hollows, and the poet's own declaration that she will cease to trust his words. Only the language of touch remains: it is a rural experience that nobody can give an etymology for; it must be lived. In "Samarthapad" ("Equivalent Word"), the poet supposes that he will not utter his dreams, for if they spoke they would pronounce all your names. There is no weakness in the verbal roots of words, no shortage of prefixes and suffixes. Yet no synonym can be pronounced: the language of an inaudible vision has departed with the hooves of horses. A new *Amarakosha*, a new poem, must therefore be written. In "Ankur" ("Sprout"), four seeds of poetry germinate in the mind, and within them the words of love are written. Do not confuse them with questions whose

answers I myself do not know. Listening to the conversation, the word-hoard is divided among four poets at once; even so, the four will sing together and a sprout of love will grow.

In “Katte Baras Ke Bad” (“After So Many Years”), the poet stands in your courtyard and asks to be allowed to read a poem. In childhood you drove me away: I had broken the metre and incurred a fine (!). Among other things there was the grieving mother; no means of observing Chhath, provisions for only four months of the year, and roasted unsalted sweet potatoes as a means of survival. Let me read one poem. In “Kiai Nahi Likhai Chhi?” (“Why Do You Not Write?”), the answer is a full stop: not one more line in your name. Why insist that a love letter must be written in somebody else's alphabet, dressed up with colour, meaning, clothing and agitation? There is the language of drying lips and fingers playing on the soles of the feet; there are marvellous inland words and the arrangements made of them. Then do not reproach me for not writing a letter.

In “Rajhans” (“Swan”), the poem's royal swan has moved two paces away from your body. Falling meteors and other disturbances have left it no respite, and even your body has not been put to use. The poet will tell it to fly with you once, for as long as it can bear your weight. The poet's simile of a teardrop is hidden under the edge of a sari. He will ask the swan to lay aside the curiosity of the young woman into whom it has turned. In “Anher” (“Darkness”), a bird tells the poet not to utter anything secret, or darkness will follow. Last night a poem arrived and lost herself in the crowd of prose. A secret history runs from sinful love to marriage, and so on. Why be afraid? Nobody will ask your name. But tell me, bird: what did you know of the poet whose grave has only just been dug?

In “Ek Ahi Chhi” (“You Alone”), I have called to you again and again in poems, yet you never turn to look. These are no ordinary records of love with a balance sheet of gain and loss, no casual invitations, no food laid out for commonplace guests. I have given you a name in the poem that a chirping bird could pronounce, not one around which some sensational story could be spun. Still you say nothing. In “Puratan Prem” (“Ancient Love”), an old love demands the price of a song, posing questions and demanding answers—although where is there room for such an exercise in nature's school? Ancient love is confined between the textbook and the history lesson: use the old word in a sentence; are all the sentences true or false? Explain the sense. But I have now become shrewd. I can read the anguish of the *mandakranta* metre and measure the chastity of the pure *dhaivata* note. My blood has truly recognised the savagery of life's mathematics. I speak less; when I speak, it is not towards the past but towards an unstruck, still-unarrived spectral time. My perception moves

towards what has not been spoken or translated. An embankment in a banana field, haunted cattle and the old love have left it all grimy.

In "Chah" ("Desire"), if I want something, what indeed can I want? You are infinite and, beyond all adjectives, you can fulfil the wish of my heart in an instant. But by the time I desire, the suffix of this whole deception is already there: my life is a *sup-ting-antam*, a form inflected with nominal and verbal endings, bound in a phrase and diminished into a lexicon. I can offer the short, the exceedingly short, the *omkara*, the form of a Vedic verse. My small desires, language, feelings and sufferings remain irregular, while the fragrance of raga Yaman-Kalyan is held in restraint.

In "Hamar Pati Ke Lel—1" ("For My Husband—1"), a hole has opened in your roof; the bitter winter wind has chilled the rice-starch water, and tears falling from the sky have soaked my sweet potatoes. The bedding is wet and you are silent. This hole will finish you. At least write the song of that destruction with your own hands. In "Hamar Pati Ke Lel—2", he says my place is upon his head, but I will not remain there among the scanty hair and the topknot. In his heart? Not beside the apparatus of breath. In his eyes? Not with the tears beneath his spectacles. On his lips? I will not become a rosary bead for prayers. On his tongue? For the flavour of cooking, yes, perhaps, but how to get out again? Under the shoe on his foot, on the earth—I understand politics. Once I understand how the shoe rises from beneath the foot to the top of the head, I will have learnt the first lesson of resistance. In "Hamar Pati Ke Lel—3", do not ask about the grammar or script of this poem. Do not tell me to throw it in the fire. What if I am illiterate? I am a magic wand and can spin. Why should it surprise anybody if someone writes a poem on me and grammar upon my consciousness? I will not call it empty pretension.

In "Hisab" ("Accounting"), five words fill Hiriya's shoulder-bag when he goes out to work at dawn. One is spent eating unsalted sweet potato; half a word is used up when Bhusahu Babu, sheltering under a peepal tree in the rain, kicks him three times. One and a half remain, and those are pledged at Chuhara's liquor counter in the Chamar hamlet when he drinks on credit. The remaining words—seven times fourteen of them!—he keeps for buying goods at the market. By evening not a single word remains to place upon Hiriya's heart. How can he then open his heart without words? He stands beneath the dew in the courtyard all night.

In "Atmakathan" ("Self-Account"), I wish to tell you something of my mind, Kapalakundala. But a female singer has been placed before the striking labourers' leader. A street-performer reads my poem while I, in a distant field, wear a rope around my waist. Let us then speak of something other than poetry. Yet there is no rasa, no word, no blow left, nor even a

name of mine suited to this terribly prosaic life. Let us ask a few questions beyond the boundary walls of prose: in which grammatical person and number is one entangled, in what forest of tense and case? The indeclinables have been destroyed, the adjectives stripped of their clothing, the substantives pulled down from their throne. Is anybody capable of reading a feeling from a prefix? Panini's hand is caught in the tangled locks of manhood, and he will cry out through Maheshvara's aphorisms if I try to speak to you. Patanjali and Hemachandra press the poet down and explain the second person singular: *tvam, tvam, tvaya, tubhyam, tvat, tava, tvayi*. O Kapalakundala, in the mind all rules, classes and objectives disappear, while you alone stand at the centre, singular.

In "Ahi Sa Prem, Ghrina Ahi Sa" ("From You, Love; From You, Hatred"), love comes from you, hatred from you too. On the day of the final truth, hang me, so that you may no longer hear me. Before you can swallow me, I shall throw you away. I have removed all the lamps from beside you. I love, but hate more. I have brought the eyes, hands and both lips to an end. Yet your laughter turned an untrue word into ice across my philosophy; then life begins running once more through every vein. In "Kani Ta Jagah Chhori Diyah" ("Leave Me a Little Space"), leave a place in this corner, beneath a pile of letters, for my desire. It was I who wrote of you and wished to fashion a poem. I need space because a poet has three feet: one covered in bestiality, another with ink dried on its tip, and the third a counterfeit heart. If you want a poet like me, leave me a little room.

In "Bhay—1" ("Fear—1"), there is the Atharvan poet and the anxiety that his book may be stolen. Perhaps the poems would then pass under somebody else's name, and the poet would be excluded from history. It costs money to keep me alive and takes arrangements to prepare my funeral pyre, decorated with profound mantras; how many histories must be written upon the anger of my poems? In "Bhay—2" ("Fear—2"), deceit will come, but now I fear nobody: I have learnt the arts of swimming and of sinking to the lowest depth, and even of being destroyed. Can an unheard word awaken hares and owls, and a touch from someone deemed untouchable awaken hunger? I am no longer toothless; a full set of teeth has appeared. Harsh words, cool breasts, long sentences, tender compositions, Vibhishana's commentary and scattered texts—all are overwhelmed with meanings and mismeanings.

In "Namkaran" ("Naming"), the moon is called *chandrama* and the stars *niharika*, and the meaning of night changes. Call the light *pratyusha* and the sun *martanda*, and the eyes are dazzled. Call the jungle a pleasure-grove and grass and straw the sacred *durvakshata*, and a mantra seems to recite itself. Rename relentless labour 'untiring endeavour', or the joining of incongruous words a 'compound', and a

broken heart is suddenly soothed. Life seems to belong only to the living —and only to you and me, or whoever continues living under a changed form, trusting the changing horoscope and its calculations on every lunar day. If I am called Dushyanta and you Shakuntala, then I shall remain anxious about Kanva and the fawn.

In "Ajuk Kavi, Bar Uchchhrinkhal Kavi" ("Today's Poet, Such an Unruly Poet"), the poet is bound in ropes of metre and non-metre, caught and wounded, rubbed raw, cooked and burned in the consonance of ornament. Let the mountains not be leapt over or made to roar: keep singing the *dhaivata* note. Poet, become your own line and cross beyond it into the poet's courtyard. Here come the poets—*kavih, kavi, kavayah*—to a modern tune. Critics will make the poem metrical, fettered and worshipped by their ways of thinking, leaving it a half-poem, a half-anti-poem, an Ardhanarishvara poised upon a half-man. How unrestrained is today's eminent poet, this 'Hatanarishvara'! In "Ahan Nahi Bajalahun Kichhu" ("You Have Said Nothing"), you have uttered nothing until now; you have buried your store of words beneath the ground, where corpses are buried. But I am also a religiously frenzied Hindu devotee: even in death I shall not go underground. I shall burn and flare, singing my song in the flames until nails and hair vanish. Which discipline or scripture taught us to put a bridle upon feeling? Let the body remain hidden beneath pride and ornament; lock the throat so that no sound comes forth. Yet I am a Suryavanshi Rajput; my weapons are words, meanings, sounds and scripts. If I lose in argument I shall surrender, but whether I lose or win, I shall certainly speak. The lighting apparatus lies helpless; the signals of red, green and yellow are mute. I peer into your scheme to strip me of clothes and weapons, to make me tell a lie with a half-truth, to steal nectar while seated in the line: life, staked upon a signifier, has become a corpse-word. Still I hope that you will speak—or, failing that, that I shall burst into one of my own songs.

In "Apan Kavita Sunau!" ("Recite Your Poem!"), you took me, your former lover, to the new house on the mountain summit. I ask the clouds for directions, and they smile obliquely at the sight of us together. But neither the clouds, stars, zodiac and ascendant, the sky's geometry, nor the arithmetic of fate made the error that led to our separation. Our final meeting took place in a crater on the moon. The stones and the geography of darkness were not to blame. The signs of sun and earth and the stars' signatures conspired together to bring about separation and prevent either of us from uttering a memorable line or word. Silence tightened its grip upon our throats. Yet neither silence nor the inscriptions on the walls were to blame: we had simply never learnt to read their alien letters. The hollow filled with your poems. I tried, unsuccessfully, to climb the rising lines to their summit, but do not blame the lines. You do not have a monopoly on

betrayal. Now I have learnt your language; I can climb the mountain burning with desire and read every line, poem and inscription. I have learnt to decipher your signature. Yet on this inscription you display the amounts of rebar, timber, sand and cement, doors, hinges and flooring! What I want to hear are a few poems, spoken by you in your language, which has now become my language as well.

In "Jivani" ("Biography"), should there be the mutiny in the cantonments, Tantia Tope, Victoria, the birth of Rabindranath the government poet, and the debate over widow remarriage? The first page of theatre history: has a worm eaten an entire page about Herasim Lebedev? But the pioneers of today's theatre do not mind if that page is missing. On the reverse is an article on Michael Madhusudan, and another on the beginnings of modern poetry; how would an ill-read poet born after 1990 know any of it! That is why such a chameleon as I can never be satisfied. Then comes 1951, the birth of this century's government poet, childhood poverty and neglect, Vivekananda's fabricated tale and fragmentary sayings. Must Girish Ghosh, Sir Ashutosh, Netaji's escape and the Mahatma's imprisonment precede my own story? False! For does history begin only with the appearance of Godse and my own birth? Then come a shattered geography, mathematics of appropriation and classical divisions of caste, the very summit of suffering. Set my heart right, you official biographer of mine! Every chapter you write about me ought to begin in 1951. There is my stepmother, the matriarch of the family, and the invented story of a grandmother who becomes the princess of Sonbarsa. How did poetry arrive, and what of the woman who entered my life? I relinquish the commission: go and find someone else, an unborn or unknown nameless poet. Until then, poetry herself will look after me and tell the story of my life.

In the title poem, "Madhyamapurush Ekavachan" ("Second Person Singular"), comes the command to think of someone other than you. But trees, flowers and stones are deceptive, and treacherous grammar has spread its net everywhere. You are the second person singular! Politics, the mountainous debt of the nation, corrupt appointments … You are the second person singular, but … Write of the injustices of Navya-Nyaya, heap up the categories of Vaisheshika, forget the grammar of wealth. You are the second person singular, but … The aesthetic essence of erotic rasa and suggestion proves useless, merely momentary. From a lifetime to Jatayu's sacrifice to rescue another man's Sita; to the Gita. *Chalati, chalatah, chalanti*: poetry flows as a truthful stream of speech, as though grammar itself were flowing. You are the second person singular, but … How can I think of anything that leaves you out?

Poetry: very few people read it. In campaigns to promote and disseminate languages such as Sanskrit, conversational camps employ simple Sanskrit. Fiction and novels are translated into Sanskrit from modern languages, but poetry remains outside this process. The reason is that nobody reads poetry; translating it into a language that has come to require instructional camps is considered a wasteful expenditure of energy. The situation of Maithili has become such that if the villages were to disappear today, the number of its speakers would fall drastically. People would speak Maithili only at seminars and gatherings. There is already a felt need for camps teaching Maithili pronunciation. In such circumstances, what need or justification is there for writing poetry in Maithili? Emphasising the claim that one writes poetry for want of time makes this predicament even more alarming. The events of one's neighbourhood, personal ambitions, accusations and accounts of travel have consequently become the subject matter of Maithili poems. But why not write prose about these things? A story is adapted into drama for the stage; to what end is prose converted into a poem? The readers of this poetry, supposedly composed for lack of time, are factional critics and those 'great poets' who turn prose into verse and use their own prefaces to write favourable reviews of their own poems. Who, then, will understand the worth of making poetry? An individual experience of the material world that never penetrates deeply cannot become great poetry merely by rhyming. Metaphysical reflection, however abstract, cannot move us either if it fails to touch the material world, whether it is free verse or enjoys the backing of a clique or ideology. Human beings need food, clothing and shelter, and only thereafter metaphysical speculation. The Buddha asks whether those participating in festivities know the inevitability of death; if they do, how can they participate so blithely? Likewise, when modern Maithili poets see the linguistic, cultural and economic ground disappearing beneath their own feet and nevertheless shut their eyes to this truth, they cannot bring sharpness to the political positions on domestic and foreign events that they try to force into poetry. Nor does their patronising desire to write 'for' the indigenous Dalit community, doing that community a favour, acquire any edge. But when Rajdev Mandal writes:

...

> From drops of blood falling, drip by drip,
> the earth is being bathed.
> A bird asks itself this question:
> Will the black and heavy night ahead
> leave any of our kind alive ... ?

The poem sends a shiver through us. Is the 'kind' here the poet's species as a poet, the bird's species, or ... ? Why should such a poem require factional intrigue and a self-satisfied preface? What political clique or sect must

sponsor this feeling? What poetry requires is excellence. It requires a foundation in language and culture. It does not need merely imported subjects, brought as though someone were conferring a favour upon it. Nor does it need imported sentiment that amounts only to a patronising, hurried attempt to discover the linguistic, cultural and economic foundations disappearing under its feet. A good poem can be written on any subject. It may take up the Buddha's anxiety about humanity's future and give strength to a troubled mind; otherwise people will keep going to the sermons of fraudulent holy men. It may address the linguistic, cultural and economic foundations of society; otherwise Maithili itself will come to require instructional camps. Images must also communicate: otherwise a suitable atmosphere will have to be arranged for the poet in advance, a stage prepared for the poem, camps organised to train audiences in the poet's vocabulary and doctrine—and poets are already doing just that. Literature ought to include the gentle rises and falls of the language of Mithila, the many-sided gifts of its working class, and equally its rigid conventions of life and culture, its politics, daily routines, social norms, economy, morality, religion and philosophy. Without them, literature will become one-sided, tip over, and turn into something fit only to be framed and hung on a wall. The making of poetry is a literary necessity. On the day people in Mithila begin to feel that they need camps to teach them Maithili, the existence of poetry itself will become questionable. The poet must remain vigilant to prevent that day from arriving. Here Nachiketa's *Madhyamapurush Ekavachan*—*tvam, tvam, tvaya, tubhyam, tvat, tava, tvayi*—stands before us in distinction from the first-person forms *aham, mam, maya, mahyam, mat, mama, mayi*.

59. The Nine Planets of Drama (*Natya-Navagraha*)

Abstract

**Kamalak Bhagata · Danavir Dadhichi · Apala Atreyi · Bha Jayab Chhu · Jalodip.* Editor, Videha: the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (since 2000) | ISSN 2229-547X. 1. *Kamalak Bhagata*: A Comic Dissection of Symbols, Tradition and Blind Imitation.*

Keywords: drama · nine planets · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · सारांश

This chapter examines "Gajendra Thakur—Natya-Navagraha". The present book collects reviews of nine Maithili plays by Gajendra Thakur: Kamalak Bhagata, Danavir Dadhichi, Apala Atreyi, Bha Jayab Chhu, Jalodip, Sankarshan, Ganga Bridge, Machand and Ulkamukh. The first five belong to children's drama and the remaining four were written for adult audiences. This division, however, is merely administrative. Together the nine plays constitute a continuous vision of theatre, from the sutradhar's direct lesson in Kamalak Bhagata—"Ask, understand, and then act"—to Acharya Singh's profound maxim in Ulkamukh—"An incomplete text cannot become oblivion; only a complete text can be forgotten."

An Interrelated Critical Study of Nine Maithili Plays

Kamalak Bhagata · Danavir Dadhichi · Apala Atreyi · Bha Jayab Chhu · Jalodip

Sankarshan · Ganga Bridge · Machand · Ulkamukh

Playwright

Gajendra Thakur

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Conclusion: Nine Plays, One Dramatic Philosophy

Introduction: Nine Plays, One Vision of Theatre

This book brings together reviews of nine Maithili plays by Gajendra Thakur—*Kamalak Bhagata*, *Danavir Dadhichi*, *Apala Atreyi*, *Bha Jayab Chhu*, *Jalodip*, *Sankarshan*, *Ganga Bridge*, *Machand* and *Ulkamukh*. The first five belong to children's drama, while the

remaining four were written for adult audiences. But that distinction is only administrative: together the nine plays present a continuous vision of theatre. At one end stands the direct instruction of the sutradhar in *Kamalak Bhagata*: “Ask, understand, and only then act.” At the other stands Acharya Singh's profound proposition in *Ulkamukh*: “An incomplete text cannot become the poet's memory; only a complete text can become forgetting.” One play teaches the child spectator to question; the other teaches the adult spectator to understand the politics of remembrance. Between them lie seven steps, each probing the steps that precede and follow it.

This book adopts a method on two levels. The first is an independent review of each play, considering its narrative construction, arrangement for performance, organisation of rasa and ideological substance. At the second level, each review traces its relations with the other eight plays—what Julia Kristeva calls intertextuality. No text is born alone; it is woven from quotations, echoes and transformations of other texts. Since all nine plays come from a single playwright, their intertextuality is deliberate rather than accidental. Both *Dadhichi* and *Jalodip* end with the same whispered words: “That is the real point.” The teenage girl in *Bha Jayab Chhu* is named Apala, recalling the heroine of *Apala Atreyi*. Both *Sankarshan* and *Ulkamukh* are divided into *kallolas* rather than acts. The drum in *Ganga Bridge* and the folk songs in *Ulkamukh* carry popular memory alongside written history. Once these connections are recognised, the nine plays appear not as nine separate books but as a dramatic *navagraha*—a constellation of nine planets.

Theoretical tools have been selected according to the subject. On the Indian side, the study draws upon Bharata's arrangement of rasa in the *Natyashastra*, the distinction between *natyadharmi* and *lokadharmi* representation, the tradition of the sutradhar and the divisions of stagecraft; Abhinavagupta's *sadharanikarana*, or universalisation; Anandavardhana's *dhvani*, or suggestion; Kuntaka's *vakrokti*, or oblique expression; Kshemendra's conception of *aucitya*, or propriety; and the critical criteria supplied by Maithili's own *kirtaniya* theatre and folk-ballad traditions. From Western and modern theatre come Aristotle's *Poetics*, Bergson's analysis of laughter, Brecht's epic theatre and learning plays, Piscator's documentary theatre, Badal Sircar's Third Theatre, Safdar Hashmi's street-theatre tradition, Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed, the Theatre in Education movement, Peter Slade's theory of child drama, the educational approaches of Brian Way and Dorothy Heathcote, Bruno Bettelheim's psychology of folktales, Lev Vygotsky's theory of play, Erving Goffman's work on stigma, the modernist outlooks of Kafka and Pirandello, Walter Benjamin's philosophy of history, and Jan Assmann's theory of cultural memory. No theory has been imposed upon a play from

outside: each critical measure is applied only where the text itself calls for it.

It is useful to clarify here the theoretical distinction between theatre for children and theatre for adults. Peter Slade sees child drama not as a miniature version of adult theatre but as an autonomous art form animated by play, participation and a circular performance space. Dorothy Heathcote, through her "Mantle of the Expert", teaches children to think from within knowledge by placing them in the position of experts. All five children's plays are tested against these criteria. They do not make children passive recipients of moral instruction; they enable them to ask questions, participate in play and undertake commitments. The adult plays move in the opposite direction: they fracture the audience's habitual beliefs and, in Brecht's terms, make the familiar strange so that spectators think instead of being carried away by emotion. One kind of theatre joins children to the world; the other teaches adults to challenge that world. These nine plays constitute the bridge between the two.

The sequence of reviews also constitutes a reading journey. First come five children's plays: folktale in *Kamalak Bhagata*; Vedic narrative in *Danavir Dadhichi* and *Apala Atreyi*; and contemporary crises in *Bha Jayab Chhu* and *Jalodip*. Then follow four adult plays: individual vanity in *Sankarshan*; the violence of institutions in *Ganga Bridge*; the conflict between state power and terror in *Machand*; and, finally, the great battle over memory in *Ulkamukh*, which draws all eight earlier plays into itself. Readers may take each review separately, but the real pleasure of their intertextual connections emerges when they are read in sequence.

1. *Kamalak Bhagata*: A Comic Dissection of Symbols, Tradition and Blind Imitation

Kamalak Bhagata is the shortest work in this cycle of plays and perhaps the sharpest. Its subtitle announces its purpose: "A pointed, humorous and instructive children's play about blind imitation." The sutradhar tells us at the outset that the plot is based on a well-known story from Sanskrit literature. The narrative is straightforward. A beggar arrives to bathe in the Kamala River, bringing a little packet of money saved over a year and dreaming of going to Janakpur to become a devotee of the Kamala. Afraid of theft, he buries the money in sand and raises a mound over it with his foot in the shape of a Shiva-linga to mark the spot. What happens next is the play's true dramatic event. Bathers arrive one after another, mistake this linga for the local ritual prescription and each make one of their own. The stage fills with cries of "Har Har Mahadev," while the beggar returns from his bath to find his marker lost in a sea of Shiva-lingas. The

sutradhar's concluding words are the play's seed-mantra: "The sign was made for oneself; it became a tradition for everyone."

In Bharata's theory of rasa, the enduring emotion of the comic rasa is laughter, and he distinguishes two kinds of laughter: *atmastha*, in which the character laughs, and *parastha*, in which others laugh at the character's behaviour. The comedy of *Kamalak Bhagata* is entirely *parastha*. Nobody on stage laughs: the beggar is serious and the bathers are devout. Yet laughter sweeps the audience because spectators know something the characters do not. In dramatic criticism this is dramatic irony, and it matters especially for young spectators: children are placed in a position of superior knowledge, giving them confidence and enabling them to experience the lesson as their own discovery rather than an instruction imposed on them. Seen through Anandavardhana's theory of *dhvani*, the final words of the sutradhar are equally significant. Their literal meaning describes an incident at a bathing place, but the suggested meaning extends across ritual observance, social custom and the culture of herd-like imitation. The work also satisfies Kshemendra's criterion of *aucitya*, or propriety. The punishment in this children's play is not violent. The beggar is not beaten; his money is merely lost among the replicas of his own marker. The consequence follows from the logic of the story instead of being imposed from outside it.

By Western criteria the piece approaches Brecht's *Lehrstück*, or learning play, which seeks to develop a capacity for analysis while providing pleasure. At the end all the characters turn towards the audience and say in unison: "Ask, understand, and only then act. Do not imitate with your eyes shut." This is Brechtian direct address: the fourth wall is broken and spectators become the judges. Bruno Bettelheim explains the psychological work of folktales as a safe imaginative enactment and resolution of a child's inner fears—here the fear of losing one's possessions. The beggar's loss cautions rather than terrifies children because, at the end, the community acts together to gather up the sand: an image of repair following loss.

Intertextually, *Kamalak Bhagata* is the seed-play of the cycle. Its central malady—repeating an action without understanding its cause—returns in adult form in *Sankarshan*. There three black dogs are beaten in turn at Madhur's shop, and each calls the blow a warm welcome and sends another dog down the same road. The crowd of bathers in *Kamalak Bhagata* has condensed into three figures, and a new layer of self-deception has been added to the disease of imitation. *Jalodip* and *Bha Jayab Chhu*, by contrast, offer an antidote: their children question instead of following the crowd. Where *Kamalak Bhagata* diagnoses the malady, those two plays teach its treatment. In *Ulkamukh* the same affliction appears in its

most terrifying form in Acharya Sarabha's rote instruction: students are made to memorise a text without understanding it. The movement from imitating a Shiva-linga to imitating scripture gives this dramatic universe one of its most consistent lines of concern.

As for limitations, the play is built upon a single incident and a single satirical thrust. Its performance therefore depends on disciplined pacing and sound design. The directions in the text—the sound of begging, the clink of coins, the flow of the Kamala, the rustle of digging sand, the crowd's chants and the final silence—create a complete acoustic architecture. That last moment of silence, when the crowd realises that it has followed a rule without understanding why it was devised, is the greatest theatrical moment in this little play. Few children's plays achieve such a complete dramatic circle in such a short span.

2. *Danavir Dadhichi*: From a Legend of Bones to the Gift of Knowledge

The boldest decision in *Danavir Dadhichi* appears in its subtitle—"A Vedic Dramatic Ballad on the Defence of Knowledge, a Promise and Truth." The stage directions explicitly state that in the revised text Dadhichi's gift is not presented as the legendary donation of his bones but as the safeguarding of knowledge, a promise, eligibility and truth. At the end the sutradhar announces this reinterpretation: Dadhichi did not give his body away; he sacrificed for the defence of knowledge, his pledge and truth. The story of a thunderbolt made from bones was, he says, a later misunderstanding by the myth-makers. This is not an arbitrary revision. The account of Dadhyang Atharvana in Vedic literature is connected with *madhu-vidya* and a horse's head, with references reaching to the Ashvin hymns of the *Rigveda* and the Madhu section of the *Shatapatha Brahmana*. The familiar bones-and-thunderbolt version is a subsequent Puranic development. Roland Barthes calls myth a kind of speech that turns history into nature: something once said within a particular context becomes, as myth, apparently timeless and beyond dispute. The play reverses precisely that process. It dissolves a hardened myth back into history and meaning, telling its young audience directly in the closing lines: "A story may change, but the search for truth must not cease." This lesson in source criticism is exceptional in children's theatre.

The title itself is a theoretical signal in its organisation of rasa. Sanskrit poetics recognises three varieties of the heroic rasa: *yuddhavira* (heroism in battle), *dharmavira* (heroism in duty) and *danavira* (heroism in giving). By calling itself *Danavir Dadhichi*, the play declares from the beginning that its heroic focus is not fighting but giving, and giving not a material object but knowledge. Indra's thunderbolt strike introduces a touch of the terrible, and the Ashvins' surgical wonder introduces the

marvellous. The total maturation of the rasas, however, inclines towards *shanta*. The sage's declaration—"This body is impermanent … but out of fear for it I shall not allow *brahmavidya* to be extinguished"—is a pure expression of *nirveda*, or *shama*, the stable disposition of the tranquil rasa. Bharata's *Natyashastra* considers the direct enactment of killing unsuitable for the stage, and the play follows that restraint creatively. The two moments in which the neck is severed occur through the half-falling and half-rising curtain, together with light and sound cues. The direction is explicit: "Let sound and light create fear, not violence." This *natyadharmi* technique—the repeated lowering and raising of the curtain to select the moments of the surgery—offers a model solution to the depiction of violence in children's theatre.

Two central devices of Aristotle's *Poetics* shape the characters: *peripeteia*, the reversal of fortune, and *anagnorisis*, recognition. Both occur not in Dadhichi but in Indra. In the first scene Indra seeks knowledge through the calculation "First secure the promise, ask questions afterwards," and leaves with the threat, "Knowledge will be guarded by me." In the third stage the same Indra, thunderbolt in a trembling hand, asks forgiveness: "In the name of protecting knowledge I went to murder knowledge." This inward journey of the antagonist raises the play above a flat moral fable. By contrast, the Ashvins' argument about deserving to receive the gift—"Service made us worthy, not rank"—gives a modern meaning rooted in respect for labour to the classical requirement of *patre danam*, giving to a worthy recipient. The episode of Chyavana and the narrative thread concerning the Ashvins' right to drink Soma are also drawn authentically from the Vedic-Puranic tradition.

The deepest intertextual connection of *Danavir Dadhichi* is with *Ulkamukh*. Indra's threat—"If you impart this *madhu-vidya* to anyone, your head will fall"—and the rule of the *chaupari* in *Ulkamukh*, where outside students could not even make a copy or summary of the *Tattvachintamani*, are two historical forms of the same offence: policing knowledge. Dadhichi answers the interdiction by risking his own body; Gangesha and Vallabha answer it through song. Yet the playwright's position in both places is the same, articulated in Dadhichi's words: "There is no greater criminal than one who obstructs knowledge." Another connection is with *Apala Atreyi*. Both are Vedic plays for children; both depict gurukula life extensively and authentically; and in both, learning proves greater than the limits of the body. Apala's hymn transcends the marks on her skin, while Dadhichi's *madhu-vidya* survives the severing of his neck. The third connection is with *Kamalak Bhagata*: there the failure to understand what is imitated reappears in Indra's initial desire for knowledge as prestige rather than understanding. The final whisper, "That is the real point," returns word for word at the

conclusion of *Jalodip*. It is the playwright's signature-sound, to which the conclusion will return.

For performance, the emotional division of the three worlds—the golden tranquillity of the ashram, sharp brightness at Indra's entrance and smoky redness on the battlefield—turns lighting into a vehicle of meaning. The Sharyana reservoir and the list of weapons fashioned, including *trisandhivraja*, *suchimukha* and *vikankatimukha*, preserve the flavour of the Vedic setting. The final admonition—"The duty of a weapon is defence, not vanity"—saves the play from war fever and preserves its tranquil conclusion.

3. *Apala Atreyi*: Marks on the Body, the Disease of Perception and the Birth of a Vedic Hymn

Apala Atreyi is the third work in the cycle drawn from a Vedic source, and perhaps its bravest. Its heroine is one of the rare women seers of the *Rigveda* whose hymns have survived in the Samhita. In seven scenes the play traces the course of Apala's life: a questioning child in the hermitage; the initiation and education of girls and boys alike; the onset of a skin disease, described as white leprosy; marriage to Krishashva; her husband's growing indifference; her return with self-respect to her father's forest hermitage; her chewing of Soma and praise of Indra; her cure; and the inclusion of her hymn in the *Rigveda* at the assembly of *brahmodya*, learned disputation. The materials of the Soma scene—a little stalk of Soma chewed with the teeth; a prayer for the renewal of three places, her father's head, the field and her abdomen; purification through the apertures of a chariot and its yoke; and skin like the sun—are authentic echoes of the Rigvedic hymn attributed to Apala. The playwright translates the hymn's imagery into dramatic action without mutilating or distorting it. The porcupine, monitor lizard and chameleon in the stage setting are also derived from the hymn's symbols of transformed skin.

The intellectual centre of the play is a subtle reversal, made incisive in Apala's words: "The marks are on my body; it is your vision that has fallen ill." Erving Goffman's theory of stigma holds that stigma is not simply a bodily property but a relation established by society's gaze: the identity of a stigmatised person is severed from its wholeness and reduced to a single mark. The play seems to anticipate this theory. At the outset Atri fears that the disease is on the body but society will turn it into an accusation against the soul. Krishashva's confession—"Inside me there is a conflict between love and desire … I am confessing my weakness; I cannot give it the name of religion"—offers an honest portrayal of human frailty instead of presenting him as a stock villain. Such honesty saves the play from melodrama: Krishashva is not evil, but his way of seeing has become diseased, and the play's compassion extends to both sides. At the close,

however, the play refuses the tearful route of *karuna rasa*. Apala neither accepts nor rejects the repentant Krishashva on his return. She simply declares her new identity: “I am Apala Atreyi—nobody's object of charity, but the seer of my own hymn.” The transformation from *karuna* to *vira*—one might call it the heroism of self-respect—is the play's classical achievement. The final lighting direction, increasing illumination on Apala at the altar while dimming it on Krishashva, places the stage's seal upon it.

From the standpoint of feminist criticism, the play's most valuable feature is its movement of Apala out of a narrative of victimhood and into a narrative of creative agency. When the sages at the *brahmodya* assembly say, “The question of whether to include it does not arise. From today it is part of the *Rigveda*. Apala's name must never be separated from the mantra,” the play constructs an ideal of acknowledging the woman creator by name. Its exact opposite appears in *Ulkamukh*, where Vallabha's song loses its attribution and wanders as the ghostly song of a bamboo grove, while Acharya Singh-Vyaghra becomes a symbol through the effacement of his name. Together the plays reveal two poles in the politics of memory: remembrance with a name, in Apala's case, and nameless forgetting, in Vallabha's. The sutradhar's closing statement—“A bodily wound may heal by itself; a wound in perception heals through knowledge”—connects the cycle's learning-centred philosophy to Dadhichi's gift of knowledge. In that play, learning proved greater than death; here, it proves greater than stigma.

Several finer decisions deserve praise from the standpoint of child-drama theory. The instruction that the illness be indicated through a pale white cloth and lighting rather than ridicule unites Kshemendra's principle of propriety with modern inclusive education: young spectators should perceive the illness without treating it as something disgusting or laughable. Atri's declaration during the initiation scene—“Here girls and boys alike have the right to ask questions; questioning is the first step towards learning”—is the Vedic predecessor of the culture of questioning in *Bha Jayab Chhu* and *Jalodip*. The details of the hermitage rules—the animals of the forest must not be killed, food should be gathered from uncultivated produce, deer may roam undisturbed—likewise provide an ancient basis for the ecological awareness of *Bha Jayab Chhu*. Knowledge and nature alike are to be served rather than possessed. It is worth remembering that the adolescent girl in *Bha Jayab Chhu* is named Apala, while her male counterpart is Jayanta. By giving young characters the names of predecessors within his dramatic universe, the playwright maintains an internal chain of remembrance, confirming that this book's intertextual method corresponds to the writer's own design.

One limitation is that the list of lessons in the second scene—letters, vowel quantities, accent, Samavedic chanting and so forth—may become static in performance. But the text itself offers a solution. Apala's intervening questions—"If pronunciation is faulty, meaning changes; if perception is faulty, a human being changes"—weave the information into dialogue. As a whole, *Apala Atreyi* is a mature drama of women's dignity in the guise of a children's play, demanding not pity but respect.

4. *Bha Jayab Chhu*: Reading Maithili's First Climate-Conscious Four-Way Play

Bha Jayab Chhu makes two claims in its subtitle: to be Maithili's first climate-fiction play and to be a *chaubatiya*, or four-way street play. Its construction clearly fulfils both. There is neither raised stage nor curtain. The sutradhar calls to the crowd, "Form a circle," and the directions instruct the spectators to leave a passage for air in the circular enclosure. This round, equipment-free performance space surrounded by spectators is a foundational principle of Badal Sircar's Third Theatre—a theatre liberated from the economics of an auditorium and brought into the midst of ordinary people. It equally belongs to Safdar Hashmi's street-theatre tradition, in which the play comes to spectators instead of expecting spectators to travel to the play. The opening exchange between the sutradhar and an actor emerging from the crowd—"Will watching a play fill our bellies?"—is a genuine street-theatre opening. The sutradhar's reply—"There is hunger in the belly, hunger in the mind, hunger in speech and hunger for air"—connects the subject with livelihood. In doing so, it anticipates the criticism that environmental discussion is a luxury of the well-off.

The structure has three parts—"The Beings of Creation," "Science and Imagination," and "The Pledge"—while its assignment of roles provides a textbook illustration of Peter Slade's theory of child drama. Eight actors assume eight roles: bird and firefly (Om and Aastha), tree and vegetation (Jayanta and Apala), sun and stars and moon (Vijay and Vijaya), the unsuccessful scientist Neklal as a ghost, and Ramvati as Dream and Imagination. Slade holds that a child's ability to become an object or creature in play—what he calls projected and personal play—is a natural artistic faculty. The play makes this faculty into its theatrical form: the nonhuman world speaks from the stage, and climate crisis ceases to be an abstract statistic and becomes a matter of life and death for characters. At the level of communicating science, the play is strikingly concrete. The comparison between the cool light of a firefly, bioluminescence, and Neklal's wasteful lamp, producing fifteen units of heat for sixteen units in all, encapsulates an entire lesson in energy efficiency in one image. The eucalyptus episode—"A tree that does not quench the soil's thirst does not

create a forest merely by being planted"—argues the ecological case for native species. The song of a seed caught in a buffalo's hair and carried to a distant land sets scientific knowledge of seed dispersal to a folk rhythm. The dispute between Imagination, embodied by Ramvati, and Science, embodied by Neklal, is the philosophical pivot: "Science remains incomplete if what one understands is never put into practice." It identifies the same gap between knowing and acting that appears as imitation in *Kamalak Bhagata* and as vanity in *Sankarshan*.

A central conception of Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed is the "spect-actor": a spectator who becomes an actor through the act of watching. The third part of *Bha Jayab Chhu* enacts precisely this. All eight characters voice their pledges—"I shall plant more trees than I cut"; "I shall recognise native trees and preserve their seeds"; "I shall acknowledge old mistakes"—then extend their hands to the spectators and ask, "Tell us, will all of you do the same?" The direction instructs the performers to elicit a collective "Yes." Boal called theatre a rehearsal for revolution; here the rehearsal consists of speaking a pledge together. The use of coughing is the play's most poignant acoustic device. After the song mourning the death of trees, every character coughs, and the coughing gradually acquires a rhythm: a bodily symptom of pollution is transformed into the rhythm of art and becomes energy for resistance. The title itself is a triumph of *dhvani*, or suggestion: the innocent sound of a children's disappearing trick, *bha jayab chhu*, is filled with the terror of extinction, which the final line then negates: "If the roots survive, we shall not vanish; if the roots survive, we too shall survive."

Intertextually, the play is the companion of *Jalodip*. Both are children's plays about contemporary environmental crises. In one, the air is ill; in the other, water demands a passage. Both end in collective pledges, and in both the underlying cause of the crisis is not nature but unimaginative human conduct. Its relation to *Kamalak Bhagata* is one of reversal. There a crowd imitates without questioning; here a crowd standing in a ring is questioned and prompted to answer "Yes." The process of turning a crowd into a community makes the two plays opposite sides of a single coin. Neklal's admission—"I am an unsuccessful scientist … I could not imagine"—is the children's version of Sankarshan's final realisation: "The kick was not in the shoe; it was in my pride." In both cases the ethical climax is the admission of one's own fault rather than assigning blame to somebody else.

The possibilities for performance also demonstrate the practicality of the *chaubatiya* form. A laser light can suggest a firefly; a sheet can provide cover; and inexpensive props such as photo-strips are easy to use on a street. The only limitation is that, with eight roles being developed in parallel,

some voices, particularly Vijay and Vijaya, remain relatively less developed. In the rapid tempo of street theatre, however, the imbalance is forgivable. Overall the work opens a new genre—climate drama—for Maithili children's theatre.

5. *Jalodip*: Floods, Children and a Dramaturgy of Water's Path

Jalodip is a social children's play about flood safety and drainage, and it stands closest to contemporary reality in this cycle. In its preliminary scene there is water everywhere. A child rescued from a flood stretches out a hand and says, "I am all right. But my ..." Darkness falls before the sentence is completed. This unfinished sentence is the seed of the play's *karuna rasa*, its tragic compassion, because we later discover that the walls of the house survived while the house's laughter was carried away by water. The five-act journey begins with this grief and ends in collective resolve. Between them stands a scene that could earn the play a place in theoretical accounts of children's theatre: the game of building a landscape.

Sitting on a wooden cot, four children make a model of their locality using bowls, a water jug, wet cloth, clods of earth, sticks and an overturned plate. A drawn line is the river, a clod the village, a stick the embankment, and the upturned plate the highway—"a road by name, a wall in practice." The fourth child pours water from the jug, and it becomes trapped on the far side of the road. The entire engineering of the flood becomes visible through a game. In Dorothy Heathcote's famous "Mantle of the Expert" method, children are given the role of specialists in the knowledge they are expected to acquire; they then learn it from the inside, accompanied by responsibility. Here children become engineers in play. The adults themselves say, "Look, the children have become engineers too." The conclusion reached through the game—"The bridge was built for vehicles. What was built for the water?"—opens the adults' eyes. Lev Vygotsky's theory of play argues that in playing a child rises a whole head above his or her actual age. *Jalodip* uses exactly this theatrical device: knowledge begins to flow in the opposite direction, from child to adult.

A second strength of the play is its discipline about facts. The claim that somebody cut an embankment enters as a rumour and is immediately challenged: "What we have heard need not be true." Such epistemic caution is rare in children's drama. The contractor's defence—"It was a natural disaster ... a flood like this comes once in a century"—is refuted by people's experience: "Our courtyard has gone under water three times in the past five years." The engineer refuses to attribute the flood to a single villain and instead identifies a network of causes: the river's old course blocked, ponds filled in, settlements built on low land, elevated roads, undersized culverts—all joining to form a trap for floodwater. The

Theatre in Education movement values precisely this ideal arrangement: narrative feeling, factual analysis and a programme of action working together. The fourth and fifth acts of *Jalodip* realise all three through eight measures: relief; a map of the village's waterways; inspection of culverts; open accounts of repair costs; swimming instruction for children; a ban on throwing plastic into drains; cleaning before the rains; and development that preserves a route for water. Taken offstage, the measures could become a proposal before any village panchayat. In Boal's Forum Theatre spectators propose solutions; here the community of characters performs that work. Yet the democratic shape of the process—the headman, villagers, engineer and children each offering a measure in turn —fully embodies the forum spirit.

The title-symbol *Jalodip*, "a lamp upon water," is the play's poetic summit. On the night of the flood children float lamps upon leaves and bowls. "A lamp in the flood? The water will put it out." "That is why it needs a boat. Float the lamp on the water. A lamp upon water. *Jalodip*." The very water that took the house away now carries a lamp of memory and hope. This paradoxical image fulfils Anandavardhana's criterion of *dhvani*: the lamp is not merely an object but a suggestion. "This lamp is for my father … This lamp will not go out if we remember everything." The image of a lamp of remembrance connects the work with the philosophy of memory in *Ulkamukh*: there the force resisting oblivion is song, here it is the lamp. The whispered final words, "That is the real point," reproduce the concluding sound of *Danavir Dadhichi* verbatim, sealing both plays with the same sign of truth.

The pairing with *Ganga Bridge* is perhaps the most instructive in this volume. Both address water, infrastructure and corruption, but the distinction between the child and adult versions is unmistakable. In *Jalodip* the contractor eventually yields—"I … I shall give you the list"—and the village awakens. In *Ganga Bridge* the system crushes an honest engineer beneath a road roller. The optimism of the children's play is not artificial. It follows from the pedagogical principle shared by Boal and Heathcote that a child's experience of agency is a primary condition of becoming a citizen. Yet reading the two plays side by side reveals that the playwright is not giving two answers to the same question; he is showing two responsibilities for two ages: possibility for the child, warning for the adult. The four children's concluding maxim forms the pair's common manifesto: "Water is not the enemy; the blocked path is. Development is not the enemy; blind development is."

6. *Sankarshan*: The Disease of Calling an Injury a Welcome, and the Shoe of Self-Knowledge

Sankarshan is the first adult play in the series. Its subtitle—"A Maithili Play in Five *Kallolas* on Vanity, False Hospitality and Self-Knowledge"—encloses its entire arc in three ideas. In the prologue the playwright introduces his protagonist-antagonist: "The real darkness is in the glitter of his vanity, fear and falsehood." He announces that a shoe through which the man is cheated at Delhi's Chor Bazaar will show him the very mirror he has held before others all his life. The five *kallolas*—"The Seed of Prestige," "The Lie Takes Root," "The Market in Marriage and Boasting," "The Mirror of the City," and "The Shoe of Self-Knowledge"—trace the germination, growth, social and familial spread, crisis and dissolution of vanity like the stages of a plant's life. The word *kallola*, "wave," frees the divisions from the mechanical partitioning of acts and suggests the rise and fall of feeling. The same unit is used in *Ulkamukh*, where the waves are of memory rather than vanity: two ragas set to the same metre.

Henri Bergson's explanation of laughter is that it arises from the mechanical imposed upon the living. A person becomes ridiculous by mechanically repeating a rigid action even as circumstances change. The entirety of *Sankarshan*'s farce displays this mechanism. After receiving a scolding from the Collector, Sankarshan sits in the stenographer's office and returns to the village saying that the Collector himself detained him in conversation. After suffering a panchayat's punishment he puts on a devotional necklace, only to take up a hoe against rohu fish at dawn. On the pilgrimage to Jagannath, where custom requires relinquishing a fruit, he relinquishes sugarcane so that he can reject tea sweetened with jaggery and instead drink tea with Russian sugar made from beet. The story of three black dogs related by Bhaskar is a tale within the tale and exemplifies Bergson's other comic devices, repetition and the snowball effect. The first dog measures a blow with a weight and describes it as a *jalebi*; the second calls scalding water a hot, freshly made *jalebi*; and the third describes the closed shutters and a beating with a stick as a host pleading, "Do not go away; have some more." Each lie sends the next dog towards an injury. Bhaskar states the story's point: "This is not a tale of hospitality; it is a tale of the disease of calling injury hospitality." Here lies the umbilical connection with *Kamalak Bhagata*. There the crowd repeats others' actions without knowing their causes. Here an individual renames personal harm as prestige and makes it an example worth repeating. Blind imitation and self-deception are the external and internal forms of the same sickness of knowledge.

The play is not merely farce, however. Its satirical edge continually becomes social criticism. Sankarshan's speech poisons other people's lives. The cruel medicine containing a poisonous plant's sap could have killed a patient had Nitya Kaka not intervened: "When someone knows the truth, even remaining silent can amount to giving medicine." An unfounded fear about a telephone directory leads Gonar Bhai to tear up his diary. Kuntaka's theory of *vakrokti* treats obliqueness of expression as the very quality of poetry. In Sankarshan's speech that obliqueness operates in reverse. Every crooked statement—telling an older woman who requests a seat, "Mother, this is not a boy; he has three boys of his own"; or praising his wife with "But her complexion is a shade darker than mine"—is an ornament of self-importance. The playwright shows that when oblique expression parts company with truth, it ceases to be art and becomes a disease. A single remark from his wife offstage—"The household runs because I am not a pampered wife. If I become pampered, who will carry the dung of your vanity?"—is the play's woman's voice. Without appearing onstage, she exposes the whole economy of Sankarshan's male pride in one sentence.

In the fourth and fifth *kallolas*, the play meets Aristotle's criteria. At Aligarh, police take a bundle of *khesari* bidi for marijuana and confiscate all Sankarshan's money except twenty rupees. The man whose words frightened the village becomes a victim of fear himself in the city: this is *peripeteia*, reversal. When the sole of a shoe he was cheated into buying at Chor Bazaar in a neighbour's name comes loose and protrudes like a heart, *anagnorisis*, recognition, occurs. It is not recognition of a destiny in the manner of an Aristotelian hero, but of character: "Tell me the truth, Gonar: the kick was not in the shoe; it was in my pride." In the epilogue the sutradhar rightly says that this one line contains more courage than anything else in the play. The comic rasa is resolved into tranquillity rather than loud laughter. The final direction—"Gonar does not laugh: this is no longer the moment for laughter, but for understanding"—gives this change of rasa its theatrical discipline. Intertextually, the Aligarh incident anticipates *Machand*: the state discovers a crime in the bag of an innocent person. Here a bundle of bidi becomes marijuana; there a pressure cooker becomes a shipment of narcotics. The sutradhar's last question—"Is there not a Sankarshan hidden somewhere within each of us?"—uses the same Brechtian audience address found in children's form in *Kamalak Bhagata* and *Bha Jayab Chhu*.

A structural limitation is that some scenes in its episodic design—the story of the guru's tea, for example—can look like self-contained jokes. Look more carefully, however, and each introduces a new sphere of vanity: administration, religion, medicine, marriage, appearance, food or

geography. The episode of the son's flight—"I spent my life teaching everybody, but I could not teach my own son the way home"—opens a tunnel of pathos within the farce. Through it the play reaches its serious ending.

7. *Ganga Bridge*: History's Hammering at the Altar of Development

Ganga Bridge is a moving play about development, corruption and sacrifice, but its real subject is not a bridge: it is the writing of history—who dies, who writes, and what remains of the dead in the history that is written. The play spans five parts and eight *pallavas*, or segments, and its time-scale is extraordinary. It begins with a school celebration of the national flag on 15 August 1947 and reaches the day on which the retired chief engineer launches his own book, *Ganga Bridge*, when the new Chief Minister has already announced a second bridge beside the decaying first one. Across this historical canvas, almost the entire apparatus of Bertolt Brecht's epic theatre is at work. The repeated announcement of the drummer—"Listen, listen … workers needed!"—functions like a song-placard that both divides and connects the sequence of scenes. The two drummers form a chorus that cools events through commentary: "Whom do you call the government?" Their debate teaches a lesson in the civics of democracy in unadorned Maithili. And when the labourers freeze during the imagined conversation between the engineer and the contractor, the staging becomes a direct instance of *Verfremdung*, alienation or distancing. Spectators cannot simply be swept along by events; they are made to see that an event is being shown to them.

In the tradition of Erwin Piscator's documentary theatre, the play does not flinch from statistics or institutional detail. Thirty workers died in the previous month; three hundred died in a year; only ten families were recommended for compassionate assistance. Ramdhani's hand is caught in a machine and is covered with a sack instead of a bandage. There are the back channels of tendering and a chain of commissions running through politicians, another engineer and hired thugs. The contractor's long confession is the play's most complex ethical document. He followed the engineer's method of transporting sand and stopped paying commissions. The engineer was transferred, and the contractor returned to his former practices: "I cannot take my children's names off the school roll." The villain here is the system, not any one individual; even the contractor is its hostage. The representation of this system reaches its peak in the exchange between Chief Minister and chief engineer in which different means of disposing of the honest engineer are ruled out one after another. Shoot him? He will become a Bhagat Singh. Charge him with corruption? The raid will find nothing but a cot. Force him to commit suicide? He is not the kind of man to do so. At last the decision is made: "He will meet with

an accident." His death beneath a road roller, and the blanket of an 'accident' thrown over it, expose without disguise the state's machinery for manufacturing narratives.

The last *pallava*, the launch of the book, raises the play to the level of a philosophy of history. Hearing the chief engineer declare that "the business of history is not to reopen wounds but to bind them up, even if pus remains inside," and the Chief Minister praise the project with "The voices raised along the way were merely the dust of development; the blood that fell was the colour of sacrifice," one recalls Walter Benjamin's famous proposition that there is no document of civilisation that is not also a document of barbarism, and that history is written through sympathy with the victors. Alongside this authorised written history, the play establishes an audible counter-history: the workers' hammering, the "thak-thuk" that the drummer identifies at the end: "This is not the hammering of the bridge; it is the sound of history's bones." Writing against sound: this conflict is the adult political version of *Ulkamukh*'s central conflict—"A name may be cut from a book, but breath will survive in the song." There the *chaupari* drives the song into the bamboo grove; here power smothers eyewitness memory under a mechanical smile and repeated "Thank you, thank you, thank you." That reiterated thanks is a brilliant example of Brecht's *Gestus*: an action that crystallises a social relationship in bodily gesture.

The organisation of rasa moves a bitter satire, touched by the repellent, between *karuna* and *raudra*, compassion and fury, while skilfully respecting Bharata's prescriptions for combining rasas. The laments of the deranged mother and the engineer's widow—"Where is the document now? The eyes of these children will speak"—are pure *karuna*. The MLA's speech on applying tilak and the scramble for four half-measures of sugar scatter a little *lokadharmi* laughter across the mourning, keeping the tale watered with life. The three-dimensional journey of Child 3—from school truant looking for goats, to cart-puller, to a worker who has fled bonded labour in Bhadohi—reveals the underworld beneath the national story of development, where the ironic mantra "Free country. Free school. Free college" keeps resounding. Intertextually, *Jalodip* is its children's counterpart: culvert, embankment, written document against the realities on the ground; the community wins there and loses here. *Machand* advances another step, showing the system's violence operating through procedure. And the engineer's final promise—"If the person who gives hope is crushed, hope will not die; his voice will dwell in the drum, the hammer, the bridge's cracks"—is a declaration of *Ulkamukh*'s philosophy of remembrance on the banks of the Ganga.

The problems of staging are plain: a large cast, a leap of more than forty years, and the swift changes of scene required by the *pallava* structure. Yet the acoustic frame provided by the drummer and the ceremonial drum holds them together. Every change of scene brings back the same call, reminding spectators that the bridge is still where it always was—shaking and demanding repairs. The final irony is that even as the curtain falls the drummer is still calling for workers. The circle has been completed; the repairs have not.

8. *Machand*: The Human Being in the Triangle of Language, Justice and Terror

Machand is the most sharply contemporary work in the cycle. At its centre stands a person who has no language—more precisely, he has his own language, but nobody who understands it. Mutalif is a young Tamil speaker confined in the lock-up of a Delhi court. At the outset the interpreter, whether man or woman, sums up his predicament in a sentence: "The city that calls him a criminal cannot even pronounce his name correctly." Josef K. in Franz Kafka's *The Trial* cannot understand what offence he is accused of; Mutalif's condition is still worse, for he cannot understand the language in which the accusation is made. The intelligence officer's remark—"If justice does not understand a language, it is no longer justice; it becomes only procedure"—is the play's jurisprudential thesis. The description of the interpreter in the dramatis personae—"a bridge of words, though sometimes even the bridge remains unfinished"—is its poetic statement. Telling the story of the linguistic exile of a Tamil speaker in a marginalised language such as Maithili is itself a political act: a language ignored by the centre takes the side of another language that has gone unheard.

The most subtle stage device is a packet of food. In the first act the intelligence officer sends a packet containing the evening meal to Mutalif in his cell. Mutalif joins his hands and sobs in hiccuping bursts: gratitude and fear are both present in his crying. In the final stage direction, darkness leaves a pool of light on the empty food packet, accompanied by an echo of the officer's words: "Sometimes a packet of food gives greater testimony than a court." In Brecht's conception of *Gestus*, a concrete action gives bodily form to an entire social relationship. Here the gift of food forms a human bond outside the charge sheet between the state and the accused; the whole play tests that bond. The extended episode at Babadhām may seem at first to digress: Lulha has travelled there on foot for twenty years while grazing buffaloes, whereas Piar Bacha goes in a vehicle and keeps erecting storeys on his buildings. In fact the passage supplies the play's storehouse of metaphors. The intelligence officer's conclusion—"The foot-soldier is a pawn in chess. The king and queen are

not the country. The country is Mutalif. The country is Lulha"—transforms the chess-piece image with which he first identified Mutalif into a definition of the nation: "He is a chess-piece, a foot-soldier, a pawn. But where is the hand that moves the pieces?"

The dialogue between the intelligence officer and the terrorist leader in Act II is the intellectual spine of the play, and its arrangement deserves attention. There is no table between the two, as if an invisible ravine separates them. As their argument intensifies, their shadows begin to interpenetrate: the stage direction is itself a thesis. The Lal Denga episode within the exchange is a documentary insertion in Piscator's manner. The actual history of the Mizoram Accord is brought in as an argument for peace: "A great leader does not abandon his people in midstream." On the opposite side, the terrorist leader's accusations—"You will open a factory and he will become a watchman … Even your mercy testifies against you. Mercy, Officer, is a weapon more dangerous than power"—touch the emptiness of the state's promise of development, previously exposed in the rhetoric of sacrifice in *Ganga Bridge*. The title-word *Machand* swings both ways around this argument. First the officer says to the terrorists, "You put explosives into the empty begging bowl of unemployment. You are the *machands*." In answer the terrorist leader, seized by the throat and gasping, says, "You too are a *machand*, a government *machand* … the only difference is that you wear a uniform and I am in the forest." The exchange of the same epithet constructs the play as a mirror: each side sees its reflection in the other, and the audience is denied an easy position of comfort.

Act III brings *peripeteia*. Mutalif, released on bail, returns with an uncanny steadiness in place of fear. Through the interpreter he says that after leaving prison he had wanted to become like the officer, but the police station, journalists, village unemployment and the stain on his name would not allow him to do so: "When society cannot accept somebody as innocent, it does not take long for him to become a criminal." Measured against his hiccuping tears in Act I, the shift from victim to potential agent reveals the play's pathos: the system manufactures its own enemies. In the self-reflection of Act IV, the play turns metatheatrical. The intelligence officer recalls Mutalif saying, "I write stories … I found the plot of a story on this journey … the hero of that story will be Mutalif." The story spectators have been watching is thus being written from within, while the claim to its central role belongs to the one who previously had no recognised language. "But becoming a hero and surviving are two different things." This sentence leaves the ending unresolved. In the tradition of Badal Sircar, such a refusal of closure gives spectators responsibility rather than relief.

Intertextually, *Machand* links *Ganga Bridge* and *Ulkamukh*. In *Ganga Bridge*, the state crushes a dissenter beneath a road roller; in *Machand*, it entangles him in legal procedure. Reading the two together makes visible a progression in violence, from the suppression of bodies to the suppression effected by institutions. Mutalif's language of gestures is akin to the song-language of the cowherd Hiru in *Ulkamukh*: both are voices that power's ears refuse to hear, and in both plays those voices ultimately become the centre of the story. The earlier connection with Sankarshan's Aligarh episode has already been discussed: a bundle of bidi and a pressure cooker become criminal objects in the state's gaze. The soundscape—the court's noise, the clink of handcuffs, the interpreter's halting speech and, at the end, the city's mixed distant sounds of the *azan* and bells—makes the separation of language from power audible. Overall, *Machand* is a drama of the philosophy of justice in the form of a political thriller on the Maithili stage.

9. *Ulkamukh*: The Great Struggle Between Memory and Forgetting —the Summit of the Dramatic Cycle

Ulkamukh is the banyan tree of these nine plays. It was staged at the Videha Theatre Festival in 2012 under Bechan Thakur's direction; the text also declares that its stage conception accords with Bharata's *Natyashastra*. This is more than rhetoric. The directions put the classical divisions of the stage—*rangapitha*, *rangashirsha* and *mattavarani*—to practical use. Characters enter the *rangapitha* through the *mattavarani*, while light is focused upon the *rangashirsha*: a practice rare even on the modern Indian stage. The play is structured in *kallolas*, as in *Sankarshan*, although these are waves of memory rather than pride. The transformation of the central stage-symbol maps the play's journey of meaning. In the first four *kallolas* a solid cube inscribed with the pattern of a chessboard stands onstage to symbolise ghosts and imagination. From the fifth *kallola* it is replaced by a sphere, the symbol of reality. The text explains: “The corners of the cube have disappeared; now there is a circle that turns memory back before us.” From sign to reality, imagination to truth: this geometric metaphor, the movement from angles to a circle, gathers the play's whole philosophy into a single object.

The first half is historical in subject. Gangesha Upadhyaya, author of the *Tattvachintamani*, defended Nyaya against Shriharsha's attacks and established Navya-Nyaya. The *Dushana Panji* records that Gangesha was born five years after his father's death and preserves information about his marriage to a woman of the leatherworking caste. The play turns these archival threads into dramatic material, together with the poetic praise composed by his son Vardhamana, beginning *sukavikairavakananendu*. Giving Gangesha's beloved and wife the name Vallabha, it creates the love

story of which the scholastic tradition is silent. From this silence arises the play's central question. Commentary after commentary and gloss after gloss continued to be written on the *Tattvachintamani*, but Gangesha's poetry became an *ulkamukh*—it was lost, reduced to the trace of a name. Acharya Vyaghra and Acharya Singh, whom Gangesha mentions in his book without their actual names, come onstage as ghosts and explain their own condition: "When names are hidden, people slowly become symbols; from symbols, stories; and from stories, faults." Jan Assmann's theory of cultural memory appears to be enacted directly. Institutional, written and archival memory—the *chaupari* school and the commentary tradition —contends with living, oral memory transmitted in song. Vallabha's declaration gives the conflict its enduring formulation: "If my name is cut from the book, my breath will survive in the song. And a love able to wait seven hundred years cannot be stopped by a bamboo grove."

The machinery of forgetting appears in the episode of Acharya Sarabha and his disciples—Khikhir, Shahi, Narhiya and Bijji. There is rote learning without understanding, intended to make everybody forget Gangesha and Vallabha. A disciple who asks questions is killed: "Now rote instruction will survive and questions will die." The weapon of resistance is a sign, a hint. Acharya Singh's maxim—"An incomplete text cannot become the poet's memory; it becomes forgetting, and only a complete text can be memory"—is the play's epistemological jewel. Something that survives only partially, in an image or a song, stays embedded in the mind like a thorn and sooner or later demands completion. *Ulkamukh* is that sign. The metatheatrical quality of this first half is startling. The characters know they are imagined beings: "Am I entirely imaginary, disciple Khikhir?" "Acharya, you are imagined, and all of us are about to become imaginary." They recall Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author*, except that these characters search not for an author but for remembrance. Alongside them the whole storehouse of folk ballads comes onto the stage: the tale of Dina-Bhadri, which Vallabha and Gangesha take turns singing and enacting; Goril and Balgoraiya; Salhes and Photaragidar; Bishahari; and songs of Gosaini. The song-centred theatrical memory of the Maithili *kirtaniya* tradition becomes the very body of the play. The recurring word *narashamsi*, an encomiastic ballad of people and deeds, signals that the playwright treats folk narrative not as decoration but as an alternative form of historical writing.

From the fifth *kallola*, the play leaps seven hundred years, and its characters are reborn. Gangesha becomes Gangadhar, Vallabha becomes Kumarsuta, Bhagata becomes Jata, and Acharya Sarabha becomes King Kirti Singh, whose very name evokes the memory of Mithila's Oiniwar rulers. Gangadhar's story gathers its energy from another historical source. He refuses the sacred thread, accepts the Dalit cowherd Hiru and the sage

Jata as his teachers, establishes a school in the forest of Saptari, demonstrates the pairing method by adding the numbers from one to one hundred to obtain 5,050, marries Kumarsuta, and establishes an *Anubhava Mandala* where there are no distinctions of caste or of women and men. The play does not conceal the source of this other tradition. Jata's disciple says expressly that his teacher has returned from the south with news of Basaveshwara and insists that such things will happen in Mithila too. The history of the Kalyana-sharana movement, the *Anubhava Mantapa*, and royal punishment for inter-caste marriage is transplanted into Maithili geography. For the marriage against caste convention between Medha, daughter of a Brahmin commander, and Jive, son of a leatherworker, the king orders their eyes gouged out and their bodies crushed beneath an elephant. His words—"The throne cannot tolerate the eyes of those who have seen love beyond caste"—turn the prohibition of the first half—"If love climbs the wall of caste, all the guards on the wall catch fire"—into royal violence. Then come Madhava's covert campaign of revenge, the harsh folk-theatrical scene of Rudramati's rice, the assassination of the king and Madhava's suicide. Finally the dying Gangadhar examines his own conscience, raising the play entirely above propaganda theatre: "My only fear is that this fire of revenge may turn the Anubhava Mandala itself into another *ulkamukhi* caste … The door I have opened must not be shut again after I am gone." The danger that a movement may harden into a new caste through its own oppositional identity is a mark of self-awareness. Here Brecht's historical method acquires its purpose: a fourteenth-century narrative questions every movement of the present.

In terms of rasa, *Ulkamukh* fuses *adbhuta*, wonder—the haunted bamboo grove, airborne characters, amulets—with *karuna*, compassion, for Medha and Jive and Gangadhar's death, and *shanta*, tranquillity. Its acoustic ending is a rare achievement in sound-centred drama: the rattle of the cube and the rumble of the sphere sound together, followed by a line of folk song returning from afar, as though oblivion were losing once again. Intertextually this play is the meeting point of all eight others. Dadhichi's prohibition against sharing knowledge returns as the *chaupari*'s ban on copying texts. Apala's inclusion by name finds its exact opposite in Vallabha's erasure. The uncomprehending imitation of *Kamalak Bhagata* hardens into an institution of rote learning. The children's plays' culture of questioning—"Questioning is the first step of knowledge"—comes to fruition in the *Anubhava Mandala*. The contest between written history and the sound of the drum in *Ganga Bridge* becomes the contest between book and song; and the unheard language of *Machand* becomes Hiru's singing, seeking a path to the ears of power. If one sentence from the nine plays were chosen as the motto of the whole

cycle, it would be Vallabha's: "Cut the name, cut the song, cut the body—but where will you cut the sound of love?"

Conclusion: Nine Plays, One Dramatic Philosophy

After these nine reviews, the network of connections that makes this group of works a book can be drawn together. The first is the sutradhar tradition. The sutradhar appears in six plays—*Kamalak Bhagata*, *Danavir Dadhichi*, *Bha Jayab Chhu*, *Apala Atreyi*, *Sankarshan* and *Ulkamukh*—sometimes calling out to the audience, sometimes interpreting events, sometimes asking spectators questions. Originating in Bharata's prescriptions for the *purvaranga*, this figure now bridges the modern narrator and the Brechtian commentator. Where the sutradhar does not appear—in *Jalodip*, *Ganga Bridge* and *Machand*—an acoustic device assumes the function: drumbeat, the rumble of a helicopter, the interpreter's voice. The second link is the signature sound already mentioned several times: "That is the real point." It is whispered at the end of *Danavir Dadhichi* and returns as a collective melody at the end of *Jalodip*. This seal of truth is the playwright's stylistic mark, like a painter's initials in the corner of a picture.

The third connection is a sound produced by the body. In *Bha Jayab Chhu*, coughing after the death of a tree turns into rhythm. In *Ulkamukh*, the coughs of Bhagata and the sage Jata ring like bells at transitions between scenes, and the play breathes its last with Gangadhar's final cough. Coughing—an involuntary bodily sound that is neither speech nor song—is the most candid index of crisis in this dramatic world: crisis in the environment, in the body and in memory. The fourth connection is water. From the flow of the Kamala in *Kamalak Bhagata* to the Ganga in *Ganga Bridge*, from the devastating flood in *Jalodip* to the Sharyana reservoir in *Danavir Dadhichi*, water is at times a witness, at times a judge—"Water itself is the evidence"—and at times the deceptive guise of a demand for sacrifice: "This Ganga … she wants blood," when the appetite actually belongs to power. The fifth link is knowledge, made apparent step by step in the reviews: imitation without understanding (*Kamalak Bhagata*) → restricting knowledge (*Danavir Dadhichi*) → the right to question (*Apala Atreyi*) → joining imagination with practice (*Bha Jayab Chhu*) → the child's expertise (*Jalodip*) → self-deception (*Sankarshan*) → history's bandaging of wounds (*Ganga Bridge*) → justice for those without an understood language (*Machand*) → rote learning against understanding and the defence of memory (*Ulkamukh*). This is not a random table of contents but an ordered epistemology, from questioning to remembrance.

The cycle's own answer to the theoretical difference between children's and adult theatre is now clear. All five children's plays, in keeping with the

Slade–Heathcote–Boal tradition, make children agents of action, and each ends in hope or a pledge. The four adult plays, in the Brecht–Piscator–Sircar tradition, disrupt the spectator's comfort, and three end without resolution. *Sankarshan* is the sole exception, arriving at self-knowledge —but even that is a moment not for laughter but for understanding. The two strands, nevertheless, flow in the same river. If the children's maxim —"Ask, understand, and only then act"—is honoured, the tragedies of the adult plays, the engineer beneath a roller, Mutalif in jail, Medha and Jive beneath an elephant's feet, might be averted. The adult plays depict the future awaiting children who do not learn to question. In this sense the nine plays form a complete theatrical curriculum, from the sands of the Kamala ghat to the amulet of *Ulkamukh*, suitable for performance in schools, on village stages and in city auditoriums, either in sequence or separately.

A final proposal: if someone has the opportunity to read or stage only two of these nine plays, let the choice be *Kamalak Bhagata* and *Ulkamukh*, the shortest and the longest works in the cycle. The first teaches how an action performed without understanding becomes a rule; the second shows how knowledge memorised without understanding becomes forgetting. The seven intervening plays trace the journey of human beings, society and memory between these two poles. The words the playwright has given his sutradhar deserve to be the final line of this book: "A story may change, but the search for truth must not cease."

60. Munni Kamat's *The Price of Life* and *Chukka*

Abstract

In the series featuring invited works by authors and reviews by invited critics, Munni Kamat's one-act play *The Price of Life* and Gajendra Thakur's commentary on it appeared electronically in *Videha* and were collected in *Videha: Sadeha*, no. 13 (pp. 412–20), available through a link in the Videha archive. "You're awake; speak. You seem very troubled." Ram Ratan: "Father, I'm thinking of going away to earn a living."

Keywords: Munni Kamat; one-act play; *The Price of Life*; critical commentary; Phoolchan.

The series of invited literary works and critical responses: Munni Kamat's one-act play *The Price of Life* and Gajendra Thakur's commentary on it.

The Price of Life was published electronically in *Videha* and subsequently collected in *Videha: Sadeha*, no. 13, pp. 412–20; it is available at the indicated link in the Videha archive.

First, let us reread the one-act play.

Munni Kamat

One-act play: *The Price of Life*

Scene One

RAM RATAN: Father, are you asleep?

BHIKKHAN: What is it, son? I'm awake. Speak; you seem very troubled.

RAM RATAN: Father, I'm thinking of going away to earn money. What do you think?

BHIKKHAN: No, son. All these years I've never allowed you to go anywhere, and I won't let you go now. Whom have I besides you? Your mother put you in my lap and left this world. Since that day you have been my everything. I cannot bear to be apart from you for even a moment.

RAM RATAN: Father, I've turned eighteen now. I can look after myself. Give me one chance to see the world outside. Let me go just once; afterward I'll live with you.

BHIKKHAN: No. Your marriage is to be held this coming Baisakh. Get married first; afterward you may go wherever you like.

RAM RATAN: Father, please agree now. It's only a matter of a few days. After that I'll do whatever you say.

BHIKKHAN: All right, I shall have to bow to your stubbornness. With whom will you go, and where?

RAM RATAN: Father, Phoolchan is going to Himachal tomorrow. I'll go there with him.

BHIKKHAN: Very well. If you're leaving tomorrow, I must arrange some money. Which train will you take?

RAM RATAN: We'll catch the eleven-o'clock night train from Nirmali. I'm going now to clean my clothes.

[*CURTAIN.*]

Scene Two

BHIKKHAN: Son, come here … Phoolchan has arrived.

RAM RATAN: Coming, Father. I'm getting dressed.

BHIKKHAN: Son, Phoolchan, you live there. You must know all about the place.

PHOOLCHAN: Yes, Uncle. Don't worry. Ram Ratan will stay with me. He won't lack anything there.

BHIKKHAN: You work in a pharmaceutical company, don't you? What sort of work do you do?

PHOOLCHAN: Yes, Uncle, it's a pharmaceutical company. There are many kinds of jobs there. I do whatever work comes my way.

BHIKKHAN: All right then; that's fine.

RAM RATAN: Come along, Phoolchan!

BHIKKHAN: Son, have you packed everything properly? Keep calling me every day. You're going away from home, so be careful about traffic and vehicles.

RAM RATAN: All right, Father. Don't worry at all. I'll look after myself, eat on time, and not work too hard. I'll come back soon after seeing a little of the world.

[*Everyone leaves.*]

[*CURTAIN.*]

Scene Three

[*After arriving in Himachal.*]

RAM RATAN: Phoolchan, it's been six days since we left the village. You go off to work while time weighs on me like a mountain. Please find some work for me too.

PHOOLCHAN: All right. Tomorrow I'll speak to my employer about you.

[*The following day.*]

PHOOLCHAN: Ram Ratan, come with me from tomorrow. I've arranged a job for you at eight thousand rupees a month. That's acceptable, isn't it? If you work conscientiously, your pay will increase.

RAM RATAN: This is wonderful news for me. I'm going to tell Father at once.

[*CURTAIN.*]

Scene Four

[*Ram Ratan and Phoolchan sit eating and talking in the company canteen.*]

RAM RATAN: Phoolchan, what work do they actually do here? They didn't give me any work today. A man wearing a doctor's coat came, made me swallow a tablet, and went away. I can't understand what medicine he gave me. Four or five others were there, and he gave them all the same medicine.

PHOOLCHAN: They make medicines for different illnesses here. The company employs some people to test them, and you're one of them.

RAM RATAN: Won't those medicines do any harm?

PHOOLCHAN: No! Even if they do, is there any shortage of doctors or medicines here? Whatever the treatment costs, the company pays for it. I did exactly this work for so many years; nothing happened to me.

A MAN: Phoolchan, send Ram Ratan over. The doctor is calling him.

PHOOLCHAN: Yes. [To Ram Ratan.] Go and see what he wants.

[*Ram Ratan enters the doctor's consulting room.*]

RAM RATAN: Sir, you called for me?

DOCTOR: Take this medicine and lie down here. I have to give you some injections.

[*Ram Ratan swallows the medicine and lies down on the table to receive the injections.*]

[*Two hours later.*]

DOCTOR: Ram Ratan! Ram Ratan! Wake up!

[*The doctor shakes him and then begins to check his pulse.*]

DOCTOR: What's this? He's dead! Is anybody there? Call Dr Khurana!

DR KHURANA: What happened?

DOCTOR: Sir, look at him. What has happened? There's no pulse.

DR KHURANA: Oh no! He's dead. Which medicines did you give him?

DOCTOR: Sir, these three.

DR KHURANA: Are you out of your mind? So many medicines at once, and on the very first occasion! First you gave him a sleeping pill, then two injections of such powerful drugs?

DOCTOR: Sir, what will happen now?

DR KHURANA: This is an everyday occurrence here. Give his family compensation and silence them. And remember, we must move the body outside only after everyone has gone. Until then, news of his death must not leave these compound walls. Understood?

[*9 p.m.*]

PHOOLCHAN: Sir, where is Ram Ratan? Hasn't he finished work?

DOCTOR: I'm sorry, Phoolchan. Ram Ratan is no longer in this world. I regret it. The company will give his family one lakh rupees as compensation. I couldn't save him.

[*Phoolchan thinks to himself.*]

How shall I answer Uncle now? How can I tell him that the one support of his life has been snatched away? How will he live? O God, how could this have happened?

[*CURTAIN.*]

Final Scene

PHOOLCHAN: Hello ... Uncle, catch a train right away, just as you are. Ram Ratan is seriously ill.

BHIKKHAN: Son, let me speak to Ram Ratan just once. What has happened to my boy? I've never even seen Himachal. How can I get there?

PHOOLCHAN: Uncle, my younger brother will bring you. He's coming to your house right now. Just come quickly.

BHIKKHAN: I'm coming, son. Please look after my boy.

PHOOLCHAN: All right, I'll hang up now.

[*As he speaks, Phoolchan begins to weep.*]

[*The following day, after Bhikkhan arrives in Himachal.*]

BHIKKHAN: Son … son! Where is Ram Ratan?

PHOOLCHAN: Uncle, eat something first. Ram Ratan is all right.

BHIKKHAN: I won't put anything in my mouth until I have seen my son.

[*Phoolchan clings to Bhikkhan's neck, weeps, and tells him everything.*]

BHIKKHAN: Phoolchan, you sold my son's life for eight thousand rupees. You knew everything, and still pushed my boy into the jaws of death. You took everything from me; you have left me lifeless. Your company offers me alms of one lakh rupees for my son's death. Throw that money in its face. I want no alms! Today my son has died; tomorrow another man's son will die. Why is this deadly game being played? Medicines that ought to be tested on animals are being tested on innocent, impoverished human beings. Is there no law to stop this?

[*The curtain falls amid a torrent of weeping.*]

Critical Examination of the One-Act Play

Let me state first that the Government of India has now prohibited the use of human beings as test subjects for examining the effects and adverse effects of medicines before they reach the market. Many people, including Munni Kamat, deserve thanks for this. In much the same way, many people like Mohan Gabaiyya, the protagonist of my novel *Sahasrashirsha*, helped secure the right to information, though certain people are now desperate to take the credit for it alone. The situations are somewhat alike.

The one-act play has a single act and five scenes. Its protagonist, Ram Ratan, leaves for Himachal as soon as he turns eighteen. There are many pharmaceutical companies in Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand, established there to take advantage of tax concessions offered by the Government of India. Ram Ratan is unwilling to marry. The job he obtains at eight thousand rupees is, in fact, to serve as a human subject in tests intended to determine a drug's effects and side effects before it is marketed. He has doubts, but Phoolchan says that he himself used to do the same work. Ram Ratan dies; Dr Khurana's dialogue makes it clear that many such deaths have occurred before, and that the case can be closed by paying one lakh rupees in compensation. Bhikkhan does not want the money. He asks: "Medicines that ought to be tested on animals are being

tested on innocent, impoverished human beings. Is there no law to stop this?"

My answer to Bhikkhan, then, is that the Government of India has enacted a law. Your refusal to accept that lakh of rupees forced the government's hand. Now animals, and not human beings, will be the experimental subjects, and the demand that even such testing be carried out safely has also been met. In the course of my official duties I myself detected a case of this kind in which well-known hospitals were also involved. But why am I telling Bhikkhan this? He is only a character in Munni Kamat's one-act play, an imaginary figure. No: Bhikkhan is a name, but I have seen many Bhikkhans and many Ram Ratans as well. Mainstream dramatists, by contrast, have neither experienced "bisandh" nor encountered a Ram Ratan. Malangia-ji therefore brought his talent to an end with *Bujhta Hai Ki Nahin*. Had he paid attention to my criticism of *Chhutaha Ghail*, he had enough talent to have encountered a Bhikkhan himself in the intervening ten years. Even after ten years Malangia-ji has not understood the difference between satire and a casteist attack. The incidents involving Malangia-ji's family and members of the casteist theatrical establishment after my review have already been documented in *Videha*.

Critical Examination of the One-Act Play: The Sociological Dimension

Bhikkhan belongs to the plain-dhoti tradition: he could be from a socially forward caste or a backward one. Unlike Malangia-ji, Munni Kamat has not felt any need to label him by an insulting caste designation or as backward. Why? Because she has talent. She does not conceal her own shortcomings by announcing that nobody watches or reads art-based one-act plays. She knows that even an artistic one-act play will become popular if it has a plot. She has therefore brought such a plot to the stage.

Let us now turn to the sociolinguistic analysis of this play and compare its language with the artificial language created by Malangia-ji for characters whom he regards as lesser people. Munni Kamat allows no smoke-stained, ostentatiously dhoti-clad figure to enter her play. She understands that this is a tragedy and that such a figure would bring both linguistic monotony and the ruin of the one-act play. She is careful. Malangia-ji, however, remains intoxicated by his own assumptions. The world has moved on, yet he and the directors of his casteist theatre believe a two-tiered language to be necessary—not in response to the demands of drama, as Bengali and other writers do, but to ridicule and insult. How else would their casteist audience applaud? Malangia-ji and that theatre should still take criticism constructively, read Munni Kamat's work repeatedly, identify the

sociolinguistic form represented in it, emulate it, and improve their practice accordingly. *Videha* would welcome such improvement.

Linguistic Analysis of the One-Act Play

Bhikkhan says: "No. Your marriage is to be held this coming Baisakh. Get married first; afterward you may go wherever you like."

"This coming Baisakh": did you have the slightest difficulty with that expression? You did not. But if we look at the latest anthology from the casteist theatre—*Adhunik Maithili Natya Sanchayan*, collected and edited by Ramanand Jha 'Raman', available at the indicated link for INR 465—the same utterance would become something like this:

[Enter a smoke-stained, dhoti-clad figure.] "Well, Bhukkhan, is your son going to Himachal to earn money? Hey, Ram Ratan, don't you marry some memsahib over there!"

> BHIKKHAN: "No, Ram Ratan's marriage is to be held this coming Baisakh."

Now the very utterance that flows naturally from Munni Kamat's pen seems artificially assigned to a character constructed as a lesser person. The dramatist's deliberateness becomes visible, and Maithili is insulted. A writer such as Munni Kamat would not let this happen. Yet before the casteist theatre fades away, it has appeared in all its malice as *Adhunik Maithili Natya Sanchayan*, supported by assignments worth lakhs from the Sahitya Akademi. In this INR 465 book there is not material worth even forty paise, and it will make young people still more sectarian, without their even realising what sociolinguistic manipulation has been used. One consolation is that Chandranath Mishra 'Amar' wrote that Maithili books published by the Sahitya Akademi rot in warehouses. As the Buddha is said to have blessed the people of an evil village to remain in one place and the people of a good village to spread, so I wish this casteist dramatic anthology to remain in the warehouse and spread no further.

Weaknesses of the One-Act Play

A play has a plot just as a novel does. A one-act play is, after all, a seed-story, like a vignette in the *Hawa Mahal* programme on Vividh Bharati. I therefore hope that Munni Kamat or other writers of the parallel tradition will write a play of at least four acts on this subject or on another like it. Munni Kamat possesses such fine subject matter and such an understanding of the sociological dimensions of language that this is certainly within her powers.

Chukka

1

Munni Kamat's One-Act Play: *The Price of Life*

Scene One

RAM RATAN: Father, are you asleep?

[*CURTAIN.*]

Scene Two

BHIKKHAN: Son, come here ... Phoolchan has arrived.

RAM RATAN: Coming, Father. I'm getting dressed.

BHIKKHAN: All right then; that's fine.

RAM RATAN: Come along, Phoolchan!

[*Everyone leaves.*]

[*CURTAIN.*]

Scene Three

[*After arriving in Himachal.*]

[*The following day.*]

[*CURTAIN.*]

Scene Four

RAM RATAN: Won't those medicines do any harm?

PHOOLCHAN: Yes. [To Ram Ratan.] Go and see what he wants.

[*Ram Ratan enters the doctor's consulting room.*]

RAM RATAN: Sir, you called for me?

[*Ram Ratan swallows the medicine and lies down on the table to receive the injections.*]

[*Two hours later.*]

DOCTOR: Ram Ratan! Ram Ratan! Wake up!

DR KHURANA: What happened?

DOCTOR: Sir, these three.

DOCTOR: Sir, what will happen now?

[*9 p.m.*]

PHOOLCHAN: Sir, where is Ram Ratan? Hasn't he finished work?

[*Phoolchan thinks to himself.*]

[*CURTAIN.*]

Final Scene

PHOOLCHAN: All right, I'll hang up now.

[*As he speaks, Phoolchan begins to weep.*]

[*The following day, after Bhikkhan arrives in Himachal.*]

BHIKKHAN: Son ... son! Where is Ram Ratan?

[*The curtain falls amid a torrent of weeping.*]

Critical Examination of the One-Act Play

Let me state first that the Government of India has now prohibited the use of human beings as test subjects for examining the effects and adverse effects of medicines before they reach the market. Many people, including Munni Kamat, deserve thanks for this. In much the same way, many people like Mohan Gabaiyya, the protagonist of my novel *Sahasrashirsha*, helped secure the right to information, though certain people are now desperate to take the credit for it alone. The situations are somewhat alike.

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Even after ten years, like Malangia-ji, he has not understood the difference between satire and casteist abuse. The incidents involving Malangia-ji's family and the people of the casteist theatre after my criticism have already been recorded.

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2

Munni Kamat's *Chukka*

Munni Kamat, the author of the one-act play *The Price of Life* (2012), has now brought out *Chukka* for children.

At the age of eighteen, Ram Ratan in *The Price of Life* becomes a living laboratory test subject, employed to determine the effects and side effects of medicines on humans before those medicines are marketed. This is his

job, and in the course of it he dies. But what were Ram Ratan's infancy, childhood and adolescence like? Through *Chukka*, I shall examine that question from sociological and psychological perspectives and analyse the language by means of Jacques Derrida's deconstructive method. [For the theoretical analysis, see my *Maithili Samikshashastra*, 2022, available in the Videha archive at www.videha.co.in.]

Chukka contains twenty-four stories.

1

An Image of Faith

The mother of Kanhaiya, the son of the potter Ratnesh, has died. You will have heard many stories in which a dead mother becomes a star. Here, however, Bedara's grandfather says that God has a little child even younger than you, but that there was no mother there; so God summoned your mother to look after that child.

Does this device not astonish you?

Now let us approach the potter's wheel of clay, which shapes beautiful images of God. The child remains lying awake like a "nibadiya" after everyone else has fallen asleep; strengthening his faith, he receives an answer from God and conveys it to his grandfather. Grandfather confirms his account by citing the clay figures that break in the kiln. The child's mind is now at rest; he no longer needs a story about stars.

2

Chiniya-Siniya

In the story told by Akash's father, a bird dies of thirst. Akash decides to take water in a pot and place it with crumbs on the roof of the house.

A tragic ending to a children's story—or a happy ending born out of tragedy?

3

Golu the Elephant

When Golu the elephant grows up, his body becomes heavy. He can neither fly like a bird, swim like a crocodile, nor leap like a monkey.

Yet he accomplishes something that neither the monkey, the bird nor the crocodile could do. He becomes a hero and receives a load of bananas and a garland of flowers.

God has created all living beings differently; each has its own distinctive gift.

4

Nutritious Vegetables

Naman and his father whisper and put their heads together. Naman dislikes vegetables and secretly feeds all of his portion to his pet Tunna.

In the middle of the night he has a dream. Thereafter he begins to like vegetables and other dishes.

5

Practice

Naman wants to score higher marks than Gangesh. He learns the art of reading slowly and repeatedly until he understands—an art that India's former president and "Missile Man," Dr A. P. J. Abdul Kalam, learned from his mother. Naman comes first.

6

The Bookish Ghost

Aman and a shaggy, bushy ghost; the new-moon day; exorcists and healers.

But Aman begins to read aloud, and the letters no longer fly away.

7

The Firefly

Rama and Dulari hear their mother tell the story of Firefly Auntie: a small body does not mean a small spirit.

8

Balance

It is Golu the squirrel's birthday. Eating without chewing, continuing to eat, and jumping about while eating give him a stomach ache.

9

Selfless Love

This is a story about a cat and mice.

Here the tale is not about a cat catching mice, but about the end of the cat brought about with the help of the mice.

Every living being understands the language of affection and belonging.

10

The Magic Umbrella

Wealth, a body free from illness, boundless strength, or boundless knowledge? Wealth can be stolen; knowledge cannot.

11

Painting

It is not her elder brother's pencil but skill in Mishti's fingers that matters.

12

The Assembly at the Pond

A story based on environmental education.

A duck is needlessly placed in the dock for what human beings have done, but the heron reveals the truth …

13

Chukka

Banknotes enter Chukka's belly and go to sleep there …

Manavi will use the money saved in Chukka to have spectacles made for her father.

14

Mother Bharati

Radhiya went to school, not to study but to run errands and do chores. When there was no one to play Mother Bharati in the tableau, Radhiya, who stood holding a little child at her waist, was called upon.

15

Friendship with a Snake

Many facts occur in this story; a trader dealing in pythons appears. But the ending is delayed and somewhat slack. The story could have ended a little earlier, when the trader arrived. Fear of snakes and affection for wild creatures become confused with one another.

16

A Pair of Pigeons

The pair of pigeons think that there is plenty of food here and a guardian to protect them. Yet the very guardian who drove off the marauding cat takes all four of their chicks out of the nest for his evening meal.

17

Lord of the Clouds

This, too, is a story founded on environmental education.

Together with their grandfather, the children will dig ponds and wells and plant trees.

18

The Clever Mosquito

Who will become king of the mosquitoes?

The one who works hardest, or the one who shows the greatest self-restraint?

Read the story to find the answer.

19

The Engineer

Embankments cannot stop flooding. Give the river a course; build bridges at intervals.

20

The Customs of Mithila

Let the egret wander through the courtyard and house; do not betray its sense of security.

21

The Goat

A story based on the practice of animal sacrifice.

22

Rakhi

A story about the child Naman's understanding: if his elder sister protects him, then it is he who should tie a rakhi on her wrist, rather than she on his.

23

Shoes

Bittu wears shoes that light up. He even bows before the goddess Bhagavati without taking them off. But when he sees his father's old, torn shoes, he takes off his own and gives them to him.

24

The Village

When food, clothes and homes are available in the village, why do people abandon it for Delhi? Manavi's question sets everyone thinking.

An Image of Faith, *Chiniya-Siniya*, *Painting*, *Chukka* and *Shoes* are stories grounded in child psychology. If we examine *An Image of Faith* sociologically, the comparison with clay images in the kiln is especially apt for the child of a potter. In the psychologically informed *Chiniya-Siniya*, the story that Akash's father tells him is, for obvious reasons, not included in the Maithili syllabus. Nevertheless, one should accept education and knowledge wherever they can be found, even if they come in a form one might laugh at.

Stories based on birds and other wild creatures include *Golu the Elephant*, *The Firefly* (also concerned with child psychology), *Selfless Love*, *The Customs of Mithila* (living together), *Friendship with a Snake* (where wildlife affection and fear are mixed), *A Pair of Pigeons* (the malice lurking behind an unexpected offer of help), and *The Clever Mosquito* (qualities and signs of cleverness).

Let us now consider *Friendship with a Snake*, in which affection for wild creatures and fear of them are mixed. Nature maintains an equilibrium. If affection for wild creatures is right, does it follow that sacrificing them or fearing them is wrong? Jacques Derrida argues that Western civilisation (or, in this case, Eastern society and culture) teaches us to think in just such a manner. But a child may lose its life in the pursuit of affection for wild creatures.

Stories centred on education include *Nutritious Vegetables*, *Balance* (health), *Practice*, *The Bookish Ghost* (how to comprehend and retain what one reads), and *The Magic Umbrella* (human virtues).

Stories devoted to environmental conservation are *The Assembly at the Pond*, *Lord of the Clouds* and *The Engineer*.

Consider *The Engineer*. The embankment, once regarded as an emblem of development—while those who opposed it were labelled opponents of development—is now to be breached by a child to make way for the river, with bridges built at intervals. What was held right or wrong fifty years ago has now exchanged places. *The Assembly at the Pond* and *Lord of the Clouds* are both remarkable stories.

Mother Bharati concerns child labour, and *The Village* concerns migration.

In *Mother Bharati*, a story about child labour, some children attend the same school to study while one child goes there to run errands and

perform chores. Yet, following a court order, children of the women who sweep the school and of the gardeners who work there are also now studying in schools built on cheap land acquired with government benefits.

Children's stories, then, will not remain mere fairy tales. This collection announces the end of the children's-literature tradition which, under the Sahitya Akademi, began as a kind of *khula khel farrukhabadi*—a free-for-all.

61. *Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays*: An Introduction to the Collection, Its Architecture and a Survey

Abstract

In the long history of Maithili theatre, Kunal—the playwright, director and poet whose original name is Shiv Narayan Jha (born in 1951 at Palimohan, Madhubani)—marks the beginning of a new era and a point of departure. When the world of Maithili drama was passing through a time of transition and crisis, his entry into theatre came as a means of rescue.

Keywords: Kunal; *Kusma-Salhes*; dramatic anthology; folk theatre; the quartet of love; Maithili theatre.

Playwright Kunal: His Contribution to Theatre

In the long history of Maithili theatre, Kunal—the playwright, director and poet whose original name is Shiv Narayan Jha (born in 1951 at Palimohan, Madhubani)—marks the beginning of a new era and a point of departure. When the world of Maithili drama was passing through a time of transition and crisis, his entry into theatre came as a means of rescue. Across his four-and-a-half decades of work on stage and three decades of uninterrupted playwriting, he has not merely secured for Maithili drama its theatrical standing: he has given new life to and revived Mithila's disappearing folk-theatrical forms, including the *kirtaniya*, *Bidapat*, *Pamariya* and *Bhatua* traditions.

The anthology *Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays*, published by Antika Prakashan in 2021, is a document of enduring importance for the Maithili dramatic tradition. Its seven plays demonstrate Kunal's experimental theatrical vision, his socially engaged thought and his classical integration of folk craftsmanship. The anthology's most notable quality is that it restructures narratives embedded in popular consciousness and mythological stories through fresh interpretation in contemporary contexts.

1. Introduction: The Collection and Its Publication History

Kunal's *Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays* is a collection of contemporary Maithili drama that is stage-centred in both substance and form. These are not merely "closet dramas" written to be read; they are works repeatedly staged, tested and refined through theatrical experiment. The publisher's information bears this out: all seven plays were first performed at Vidyapati

Bhavan in Patna and subsequently published in magazines such as *Bhangima* and *Antika*. That is why it is insufficient to analyse only their written texts: theatricality, or performability, must also occupy the centre of their criticism.

The dedication page is itself a theatrical manifesto: "To the known and unknown people and artists who perform plays ('nach') from village to village, and to J. Brahmanand, the Vishvakarma of *Bhangima*." This dedication contains the seed of Kunal's entire vision of drama. On the one hand, he salutes the unnamed village performers of *nach*—the tradition that has lived for centuries in the soil of Mithila but whose names are absent from institutional literary histories. On the other, he expresses gratitude to his theatrical ensemble *Bhangima*, many of whose members, such as J. Brahmanand, were involved in the original productions of these plays. The cover illustration is by Vinay Ambar, and distinctly echoes the Mithila tradition of folk painting.

2. The Collection's Architecture: A Design of Two Circles

Viewed together, the seven plays fall into two distinct circles. Although the author does not explicitly declare this division, it becomes evident from their forms, sources and chronology.

(a) The folk-theatrical trilogy: *Chalis Chor a Gonu Jha*, *Bidapat* and the title play *Kusma-Salhes*. These three expansive, multi-character plays, rich in song and dance, are based on Mithila's own oral narratives and folk theatre—the *nach*, *Salhes nach* and *Bidapat nach*. Their dates of composition extend from 1990 to 2006.

(b) The quartet of love: *Prem-Pratijna urf Shruvavatik Jai!* [The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory!], *Vishwask Shakti urf Sukanyak Vivah* [The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage], *Premak Vistar urf Shwetak Avishkar* [The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery] and *Premak Pariksha urf Suprabha a Ashtavakra* [The Trial of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra]. These four comparatively short playlets, economical in their use of characters, derive from mythology or traditional narrative and appeared in *Antika* in 2013–14. Their titles are cast in a single mould: an abstract value—love or trust. Each revolves around a woman who makes her own decisions.

A thread binding the two circles is the establishment of love as a life principle. The refrain of the concluding song in *Kusma-Salhes*—"A flower without nectar is just so; what is life without love?"—echoes almost word for word in *Shwetak Avishkar*. In other words, a single intellectual thread remains taut from the folk-theatrical trilogy to the quartet of love.

3. A General Survey of the Plays

3.1 *Chalis Chor a Gonu Jha urf Gyan Jhak Khissa* [Forty Thieves and the Tale of Gonu Jha, or Gyan Jha]

The opening play of the collection is also its most experimental. Its very beginning is an outstanding instance of self-referential theatre. Three *bhats*, or hereditary bards, enter the stage and lament their dying art: "Our knowledge is of no use any more." When their conventional *kavitts* and songs of praise fail to affect the listeners, they decide to put on a "play" instead. In that single scene Kunal makes three historical realities dramatic at once: the decline of Mithila's bardic tradition, the crisis of arts dependent on princely patronage, and the migration of folk performers towards theatre.

Within that outer frame unfolds the familiar cycle of Gonu Jha stories. The ruler has bestowed upon Gonu the title "Crest-Jewel of Rogues"; the humiliated court poets appeal to him for justice; and eventually a band of forty thieves attempts to plunder his house. Gonu defeats them not by physical force but by intelligence. He inflames rivalries among the thieves by dangling the symbolic prize of the leader's *muretha*, or headcloth, before them and deceives them through a farcical, mock ceremony of investiture. Here *hasya rasa*, the comic sentiment, is blended in a rare way with *vira rasa*, heroism, in which valour becomes the quality of reasoning rather than of weaponry.

The play's intellectual climax comes at the end, when the *bhats* step back outside their roles and argue among themselves about the conclusion: "But in this way, brother, hasn't the ending of the play changed?" In that one line Kunal exposes the fluidity of theatrical reality, the possibility of alternative endings and the transparency of composition before an audience. Then comes a sharp social observation: theft is called a malady "arising from illiteracy and poverty", whose remedy lies not in punishment but in a just social arrangement.

At the end the *bhats* spread out a *gamchha*, or cloth, to collect donations from the audience. This is more than a realistic depiction of folk artists collecting their wages; it is a moving acknowledgement of the relation between art and livelihood. The line of the concluding song—"There is no power greater than intelligence"—is the thesis of the entire play and vindicates the title's reference to the tale of "Gyan Jha".

Read from the perspective of Navya-Nyaya, the play's central value, intelligence, celebrates *prama* (valid cognition) and *yukti* (reasoning). Each of Gonu's victories comes not from physical power but from

inference, conjecture and argument. Beneath a comic exterior lies a vernacular affirmation of epistemology.

3.2 *Bidapat*

Bidapat, the folk pronunciation of Vidyapati's name, is the most refined example of Kunal's skill as a dramatist. The title page calls it a "playlet based on folk-theatrical form"; in fact, its form synthesises the classical and the popular traditions of theatre. The drama begins with a *purvaranga*, adopts the classical dialogue between *sutradhara* and actress, and simultaneously brings onstage such folk-theatrical figures as the *samaji* chorus, the clown-like *Vipta*, and the *natua* dancer-performer.

The drama's most remarkable formal feature is its extensive, careful and meaningful use of Vidyapati's own *padas*. A hymn to Shiva, a salutation to Bhairavi, the portrayal of spring ("New Vrindavan, ever-new groves of trees … the young lover wanders"), poems of separation ("Take the moon's essence and shape a face; eyes startled like the chakora bird"), and a concluding verse in the Avahattha style: all are woven into the action so closely that the play becomes a theatrical commentary upon Vidyapati's lyric poetry.

The plot interlaces Vidyapati's life through three relationships: that with his patron and friend Shiv Singh, with Shiv Singh's queen Lakhima, and with his servant Ugna, who according to the famous legend was Lord Mahadeva himself. The final part is profoundly moving: Shiv Singh disappears during the battle of Oini; Lakhima refuses to regard her husband as dead and waits for him; Vidyapati mourns him throughout his life. Here Lakhima is not represented as an emblem of *sati* but as a determined, self-respecting woman who waits. It is a subtle rereading of the inherited narrative.

The play's *dhvani*—its suggested or resonant meaning in Indian poetics—reaches a culmination at the close. Vidyapati declares that he will live through his *padas* and that Shiv Singh, Lakhima, Vipta, Natua and Ugna will survive with him. Below the *karuna rasa* of sorrow runs a deep current of *shanta rasa*, tranquillity: poetry's immortality is established above the grief of death. In effect, *Bidapat* takes Vidyapati down from the institutional history of literature, where he stands as an image of the "great poet", and establishes him anew as a living protagonist of folk theatre. It offers an outstanding dramatic example of the parallel-history perspective associated with *Videha*.

3.3 *Kusma-Salhes*

Its position as the title play is more than coincidence. Artistically and intellectually it is the heart of the collection. The title page describes it as

"a play based on the epic narrative of King Salhes and on the folk theatre of *Salhes nach*". King Salhes is a folk deity and hero of Mithila's Dusadh (Dalit) community, and *Salhes nach* is the folk-theatrical tradition associated with him. This choice of source is itself a cultural and political statement: rather than draw upon the elite-centred literary tradition of Mithila, Kunal bases his most ambitious drama on the epic narrative of a subaltern community.

The dramatis personae take on a fully epic scale: Salhes, king of Mahisoutha; the heroine Kusma, a gardener; Hiraman the parrot, who carries the story; Vipta, clown of the folk theatre; Salhes's animal companions, the tiger Thanka and the bear Banka; the yogini sisters who are gardeners; such realms as Morang, Bhot, Baghgarh and Samdagarh; and the goddess Durga herself. This breadth preserves the original folk structure of *Salhes nach*: *purvaranga*, *sumiran* or invocation, communal choral singing, and geographical journeys enacted scene by scene.

The opening *sumiran* is an extraordinary declaration of religious and cultural syncretism. Along with the gods, the village deity Baba Dihbar, gurus, the rising sun, the Ganga and Gora-Parvati, it invokes to the west "Mira-Sultan", a Muslim *pir*, and ends by remembering "the whole community" and the "people's hearts and minds". The greeting to the spectators is equally inclusive: "Pranam, namaste, adab, good evening, salaam." This syncretism belongs to the cultural character of the Dusadh Salhes tradition itself, and Kunal brings it to the stage with fidelity.

The heroine Kusma's account of herself—a princess who abandoned the palace to become a forest-dwelling gardener—is charged with folk-poetic intensity. Her memory of pilgrimages to Janakpur, Kamru-Kamakhya and Visunpur, and of Durga's message in a dream when she was twelve years old, supplies the emotional setting. But the play's central struggle is not simply about love: it is love in conflict with the lust for power.

That conflict reaches its peak when the expansionist emperor Suchong chains Salhes in the prison at Rangilagarh and dreams of sole dominion over all Mithila. Salhes's answer speaks the soul of the play: "My life may be in your fist, Emperor. But my thoughts and feelings cannot be chained. Salhes may not remain, but a people filled with the creed of a life without fear will remain." With this one speech Kunal transforms the Dusadh folk deity Salhes into a popular hero, a symbol of fearlessness and freedom, and the gardener sisters into embodiments of peace, compassion, affection, delight and public welfare.

The drama ends in collective song and dance, from which emerges the unforgettable refrain: "Love is truth, love is fragrance, the feeling of love is eternal; as a flower is without nectar, so what is life without love?"

Shringara rasa here rises above its mundane level and becomes a universal human principle. Love is no longer an individual attachment but a creative force of the world. This is the strongest play in the collection: fidelity to a folk source, political consciousness and poetic achievement meet in one work.

3.4 The Quartet of Love: Four Mythological Heroines

The final four dramas form a coherent sequence of ideas. All four share a theatrical grammar: economical casts, multiple-role acting (one performer playing several characters), layered or empty stages, narrative presentation by a *sutradhara* or announcer, and occasional quotations from Vidyapati's lyrics. Through mythological and narrative heroines, each establishes contemporary values: female agency, self-determination and the dignity of love.

Prem-Pratijna urf Shruvavatik Jai! [The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory!]. Shruvavati, daughter of the sage Bharadvaja, rejects the conventional criteria for marriage—a handsome, wealthy and valiant bridegroom—and declares that she will marry only when someone becomes genuinely *arthavan*, meaningful, to her. Calling herself an "independent and self-reliant" person, she wishes to be an "exception" to tradition. Indra, disguised as Vasishtha, tests her by requiring her to cook a fruit before sunset. The fruit becomes stone, but considering a life emptied of loving memory meaningless, Shruvavati resolves to enter the funeral pyre. Through this strength of will she makes Indra yield. The thesis is: "Inner strength is a human being's greatest possession." Although the convention of entering the fire creates some tension with a feminist reading, the focus here is resolve rather than sacrificial submission.

Vishwask Shakti urf Sukanyak Vivah [The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage]. In this adaptation of the Mahabharata's Sukanya-Chyavana narrative, the playful young princess Sukanya meets the aged sage Chyavana, absorbed in meditation inside an anthill. The play opens with Vidyapati's spring lyric, "The lord of seasons, King Spring, has arrived." Between the queen's anxiety and King Sharyati's tender paternal affection comes a subtle philosophical exchange: "If you close your eyes, you will not see that tree … yet everything is present." This dialogue stages the distinction between knowledge and the object of knowledge: non-apprehension is not the absence of existence. The heart of the play is trust; it is Sukanya's fidelity that restores Chyavana's youth.

Premak Vistar urf Shwetak Avishkar [The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery]. This is the most imaginatively original of the quartet. Shweta, the royal dancer, falls in love with King Atiratha after seven years of rigorous discipline. Atiratha, however, remains "detached" from art. In

favour of the power to discriminate the essential from the inessential—*nira-kshira-viveka*—he insists on seeing art separately from the body, and declares that "to love would be utter foolishness." Shweta replies by quoting the poet: "As nectar is to a flower, so is love to life" (note that this is the refrain at the end of *Kusma-Salhes*) and resolves to make this "detached" king propose love to her himself. The double meaning of *avishkar* is exact: Shweta discovers love and also discovers her own agency. A character such as a dancer, traditionally constructed as an "object", is turned by Kunal into a "subject", an agent of action. This is the drama's chief achievement.

Premak Pariksha urf Suprabha a Ashtavakra [The Trial of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra]. "Trial" is central to this tale of the deep attachment between Ashtavakra, the sage whose body is bent in eight places, and Suprabha, daughter of the great sage Vadanya. Vadanya sends Ashtavakra to heaven and the company of Urvashi in order to test Suprabha's constancy; Suprabha rejects the prospect of marrying another king at a *swayamvara*, insisting that she will do nothing but "wait for Ashtavakra". Ashtavakra rejects Urvashi and returns, and the two marry. The concluding couplet expresses the play's meaning: "As gold glows more brightly in fire, so love becomes deeper when it undergoes a trial."

Comparative Table: Production History and Stage Design

Play	First performance / publication	Principal artists and credits	Principal theatrical form and tradition
Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha, or the Tale of Gyan Jha	4–5 August 1993, Vidyapati Bhavan, Patna	Premlata Mishra, Umakant, J. Brahmanand, L. R. M. "Rajan", Keshav Nandan, Kumar Manish Arvind	Mixture of folk theatre, Pamariya and Bhat styles
Bidapat	30 September 2002, Vidyapati Bhavan, Patna	Ravindra Bihari Raju, Radha Mishra, Prakash Jha, Pragati Shekhar, Raghuvir Mochi, Brahmanand Jha, Suruchi Verma	Bidapat style; craft based on folk theatre
Kusma-Salhes	Various performances; Antika publication	Local folk artists and the Bhangima troupe	Folk-epic form; Salhes saga
The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory!	Antika publication (published between 2003 and 2014)	Performers of Bhangima and Mailorang	Mythological narrative; synthesis of classical and folk traditions
The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage	Antika publication (published between 2003 and 2014)	Local and professional theatre groups	Mythological drama; introspective staging
The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery	Antika publication (published between 2003 and 2014)	Musical-theatre artists	Musical drama (Maithili adaptation of the Hindi Shweta)
The Trial of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra	Antika publication (published between 2003 and 2014)	Bhangima's classical-theatre ensemble	Philosophical and mythological narrative form

Comparative Table: Social, Intellectual and Theatrical Perspectives

Play	Social and political consciousness	Women's agency and characterisation	Integration of folk art and theatrical thought
Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha	Satire on monarchical exploitation, corruption and justice	Gonu Jha's wife as a rational and alert woman of the household	Pamariya and Bhat forms; natural flow of folk theatre
Bidapat	Democratisation of language; opposition to Sanskrit dominance and feudal oppression	Queen Lakhima's independent thought and assertion of marital rights	Bidapat form; folk-theatrical music of nachari and maheshvani
Kusma-Salhes	Dalit resistance; a challenge to untouchability and feudalism	Strong, independent and revolutionary women such as Kusma and Dauna the gardener	Synthesis of the Salhes saga, folk dance and traditional theatre
The Vow of Love	Individual commitment rising above royal power and social pressure	Shruvavati as an embodiment of indomitable resolve and self-determination	Combination of classical narrative and experimental stage movement
The Power of Faith	Mutual understanding between old age and youth; social propriety	Sukanya's faith empowers her to challenge the king of the gods and other deities	Introspective staging and symbolic scenic design
The Expansion of Love	Scientific perspective on biological and philosophical development	Shweta as an independent creative being through nature and love	Musical drama combining modern sound and lighting
The Trial of Love	Philosophical conflict of intellectual brilliance and the clown tradition	Suprabha values intellectual beauty above physical beauty	Classical delivery of dialogue and symbolic mythological staging

62. *Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha, or the Tale of Gyan Jha*: A Review of the Drama from Multiple Perspectives

Abstract

This review of Kunal's first play reads its narrative structure, humour, intellect, bardic tradition, metatheatre, folk-theatrical form and the economics of artistic labour together. It explores the drama's multiple layers through a comparative application of Indian theories of *rasa* and *vakrokti*, Western estrangement and the carnivalesque, Chinese aesthetics of dramatic structure, and Israeli ideas of iconic performance.

Keywords: Gonu Jha; humour; intelligence; metatheatre; bard; estrangement effect; folk theatre.

1. Introduction and Narrative Structure

Kunal's first play, *Chalis Chor a Gonu Jha urf Gyan Jhak Khissa*, occupies a remarkable place in the history of Maithili drama. It matters even more for its "way of telling the story" than for its subject matter. The drama begins with a metatheatrical, self-referential device: three *bhats*, the traditional bards and singers of praise, enter and lament their uselessness before the spectators. Discovering that their customary recitation of *kavitts* no longer has any effect, they decide: "What if we were to perform a play?" Another story begins: the story of the bards (the outer frame) and the story of Gonu Jha, Mithila's familiar folk logician (the inner frame).

The inner story has several principal elements: an opening examination of a child's parentage, in which a ploughman cleverly proves whose child it is; the humiliation of intelligence at the court of Subedar Bhunbhunadev; the court poets' appeal to Gonu; a journey in pursuit of justice to the fort of Ghuskiyahi; conflict over leadership among the thieves (Durmatiya versus Debaha); Gonu's dream of Mother Kali; and finally a scene in which he overcomes the thieves through an elaborate, deceitful rite of investiture. A particular note by the playwright is important: one actor can perform multiple roles in this play; there are versions lasting forty-five, sixty and ninety minutes, as well as an audio-drama series of thirteen episodes broadcast on radio.

The play's fundamental questions are these: Who will sustain art—the state, society or the artist? And in the struggle to survive, is intelligence, or knowledge, ultimately the highest power? These questions remain central to a review through all four dramatic traditions.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 The *Natyashastra*: The Production of Rasa and Character Types

Bharata's *Natyashastra* (approximately second century BCE to second century CE) calls *rasa* the life of drama: "Rasa is the life of theatre." The principal sentiment of this play is *hasya*, humour, but it does not stand alone. Bharata distinguishes six varieties of laughter; *parastha hasya*, laughter directed at another, is central here. The portrayals of the folly of Buriraj, Bhunbhunadev, Durmatiya and the band of thieves fall into that category. Alongside it is *atmastha hasya*, laughing at oneself, exemplified by the bards' self-irony.

The *alambana vibhavas*, or supporting determinants of humour, are the incongruous behaviour of Bhunbhunadev and Buriraj ("Your Majesty, I call you Buriraj because I like that name better"), Durmatiya's obstinacy and Runubhanu's helpless farce. The erotic *shringara* of the *Kamasutra* tradition associated with Vatsyayana is absent; this is essentially a comedy. Yet it has an extraordinary form of *vira rasa*: Gonu's courage lies not in arms but in reasoning. Bharata's *dhira-lalita* hero is calm, humorous and intelligent. That is Gonu's character.

The *vidushaka* tradition: in Bharata's *Natyashastra*, the clown or *vidushaka* is a distinct character type, often Brahmin, comically dressed, yet clever and friendly with the hero. Gonu Jha partly inherits this tradition, but Kunal redefines it through folk realism. Gonu is not a courtly clown but a popular logician grounded in the soil.

2.2 Farce, *Bhana* and Folk-Theatrical Form

The Sanskrit dramatic genre of *prahasana*, the comedy or farce in one or more acts, is this play's closest classical equivalent. Bharata describes farce as combining a threefold humour of mind, speech and body. All three are present in Kunal's play: the bards' verbal play, the thieves' absurd physical acts and the mental comedy of Gonu's encounter with Mother Kali.

The *Natyashastra* distinguishes *lokadharmi*, which follows popular conventions, from *natyadharmi*, which follows stylised classical conventions. This play falls unmistakably within the *lokadharmi* tradition. Direct address to spectators, songs, dream scenes and mockery through names—Bhunbhunadev, Buriraj, Durmatiya—are all folk-theatrical techniques. They differ from classical formal standards, yet are no less legitimate or traditional.

2.3 *Dhvani* and *Vakrokti*

The theory of *dhvani* in Anandavardhana's ninth-century *Dhvanyaloka*, according to which suggested meaning surpasses direct denotation and secondary indication, operates at several levels in this play.

The phrase "Gyan Jha's tale" literally names the story of a man but, through suggestion, becomes the story of knowledge and intelligence. The closing song articulates precisely this suggestion: "There is no power greater than intelligence." In that verbal resonance lies the purpose of the entire play.

Kuntaka's tenth-century *Vakroktijivita* sets out the principle of oblique expression: the marvellous, delightful expression of an object or meaning. It is found here in abundance. Bhunbhunadev's entire character is an instance of "obliqueness in naming". Consider Gonu's conversation with Mother Kali:

"O Mother! When you catch a cold ... all your hands are occupied holding weapons. Then how do you wipe the mucus from your nose?"

This utterance blends faith with humour, devotion with intelligence, divinity with humanity in an oblique fashion that makes it an excellent example of *vakrokti*. Fear never enters: this is the obliqueness of fearlessness.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Aristotle: Mimesis, Reversal and Catharsis

The Greek philosopher Aristotle (384–322 BCE), in his *Poetics*, treats *mimesis* or imitation as central to drama and identifies the importance of *peripeteia*, reversal of fortune, and *anagnorisis*, recognition, for an excellent tragedy. In one respect Kunal's play resists the Aristotelian standard: it is not a single-stranded tragedy but a many-stranded comedy. Aristotle regards the episodic plot as defective; within the folk tradition, however, precisely this episodic quality is its lifeblood.

Nevertheless, Aristotelian catharsis, the release or purification of suppressed emotions, is present here in comic form. Against the three social anxieties of theft, poverty and the corruption of the state, the play brings about a catharsis through laughter that can be defended on the socio-psychological level through Aristotle's theory.

The recognition scene is inverted. Gonu, half asleep, first "recognises" the thieves as Mother Kali ("Mother Kali has come in the guise of a man!"), and only then fails to "recognise" them. It is a reversed *anagnorisis*: the comic deployment of recognition, replacing fear with laughter.

3.2 Brecht: Epic Theatre and the Estrangement Effect

The German playwright and theorist Bertolt Brecht (1898–1956), in his theory of epic theatre (*Episches Theater*), proposed the *Verfremdungseffekt*, or estrangement effect. Actors repeatedly remind spectators that what they are watching is a "construction", not an unmediated reality, so that their critical intelligence remains awake. Kunal's play offers a vernacular version of Brechtian estrangement.

The three bards' onstage decision to "perform a play" is already an act of estrangement. Throughout the performance they never lose themselves completely in emotion, but remain conscious of their identity as performers. At the end they return to argue over an alternative conclusion and present a social interpretation to the spectators: "this social malady arising from illiteracy and poverty". That is an excellent example of Brechtian *Gestus*, the social attitude revealed through performance. The actor "shows" (*zeigen*) rather than simply undergoing an experience.

Brecht also made the economic foundations of art an issue. The episode of the *gamchha*, in which the bards openly ask spectators for donations to fill their stomachs, is precisely this kind of Brechtian transparency. Brecht wanted the conditions of artistic production never to be hidden. Here they are brought into view.

3.3 Lionel Abel: Metatheatre

The American critic Lionel Abel, in *Metatheatre* (1963), defined a form of drama in which characters know that they are "in a play". By this definition, *Chalis Chor* is fully metatheatrical. Three bards decide onstage to perform a play, choose the story they will enact, and expose the process of composition at the end. Abel says that metatheatre treats life as dream and theatre as awakening. Here the relationship is almost reversed: the bards' crisis of existence is "real" and Gonu's narrative is "dream" or play, but the same stage holds both.

3.4 Bakhtin: The Carnivalesque

The Russian thinker Mikhail Bakhtin (1895–1975) developed the concept of the carnivalesque to analyse cultural moments when established social hierarchies are overturned, restraints are broken and popular laughter ridicules authority.

The play has many carnivalesque features. Buriraj, the "witless minister", and Bhunbhunadev, the "humming god" who is a subedar, bear names that are carnivalesque commentaries on their official positions. When the band of thieves holds a democratic vote to choose a leader, politics is seen to operate even among these brigands: a carnivalesque parallel state.

From Bakhtin's perspective the *gamchha* episode inverts hierarchy. Mocking the sovereign and his court, the bard-performers establish a direct economic relationship with their spectators without an intermediary. The tension between dependence on the state and dependence on the people is exposed in carnivalesque form.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Li Yu: Principles of Dramatic Structure

The Chinese dramatist and theorist Li Yu (1611–1680), whose *Xianqing Ouji* [Casual Expressions of Idle Feeling] is regarded as a foundational text of Chinese dramatic criticism, presents a central principle: *zhu nao*, or the main governing idea. Every good play must have a central axis to which all the threads of its plot are tied.

This play's *zhu nao* is "intelligence versus brute strength" and the related opposition, "folk art versus state power". Li Yu argues that the central idea must be established in the first act, and that is exactly what Kunal does in the opening scene with the bards.

Li Yu's second principle is *mi zhen xian*, fine stitching: the parts of a play should be woven together so that all its strands fall into place at the end. The return to the bards' frame and the *gamchha* episode exemplify this: the outer narrative, the bards' predicament, ends at precisely the point where it began.

4.2 The *Chou* Character Type

In classical Chinese theatre—*jingju*, or Beijing opera, and other forms—there are five basic role types: *sheng* (male protagonist), *dan* (female), *jing* (painted face), *mo* (older man) and *chou* (clown). The *chou* role is distinctive in directly addressing the audience, breaking stage conventions and speaking a vernacular idiom.

The three bards of this play are a trinity of *chou* figures. Their addresses to the audience, abandonment of roles, use of songs and self-mockery are all recognisable qualities of the *chou*. This parallel reveals a global logic of folk theatre: each culture invents a clown who breaks the fourth wall and holds up to society a mirror of its own condition.

4.3 *Xu–Shi*: The Empty–Full Principle

The principle of *xu–shi*, emptiness and fullness, is fundamental to Chinese aesthetics. What is empty onstage—the absence of scenic objects—is made full through the imagination. A Chinese actor can evoke a boat with a stick and a journey with a single step.

The most telling instance of *xu–shi* in Kunal's drama is Gonu's bundle of cottonseed. He declares that a handful of worthless seeds sells for ten gold coins per unit of weight. The "empty" object, the valueless seed, becomes "full", a treasured commodity. This is Gonu's application of *xu–shi* through the power of intelligence. It suggests that Kunal's aesthetic sensibility accords with the essence of emptiness and abundance in Chinese folk theatre.

4.4 *Yijing*: Wang Guowei

The Chinese aesthetician Wang Guowei (1877–1927), in *Renjian Cihua*, develops the concept of *yijing*, the fusion of feeling and situation. In outstanding art, feeling and setting blend to produce an autonomous aesthetic sphere.

The play's *yijing* is the conjunction of nostalgia for the bards' dying art and delight in Gonu's unconquerable intellect. Together they create a peculiar theatrical field of feeling in which sorrow and exuberance coexist. Wang describes a *you wo zhi jing*, a scene in which the subject is present and the artist's feelings are absorbed into the world represented. The playwright's love for Maithili's imperilled artistic identity is likewise expressed in a composite form here.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Eli Rozik: The Theory of Theatrical Iconicity

The Israeli theatre scholar Eli Rozik (born 1934), in *Theatrical Image* and subsequent writing, advances a major proposition: the basic unit of theatre is the image or icon, rather than the text or story. The actor's body, voice and actions create an icon of a fictional world, in a Peircean sense. Drama is a system of such iconic images.

The image of the bards gives Rozik's theory a particular application here. What the three bards create onstage represents not merely "three individuals" but the entirety of a dying bardic tradition. Rozik distinguishes an icon from a symbol: the former is related to what it represents by resemblance. By "showing" the decline of their art, the bards produce an icon.

When the bards decide to "perform a play", they make theatre its own subject. Rozik's concept of "theatre about theatre" applies here. The medium of theatre itself becomes what is represented—an accomplished instance of iconic self-reflection.

5.2 Shimon Levy: Theatre as Archive

The Israeli theatre scholar Shimon Levy (1939–2017) has emphasised in a number of works the way theatre can become a cultural archive, a living repository of traditions, memories and practices that might otherwise be forgotten. On this view, theatre is not only an event taking place now but also a performance of the remembered past.

In Kunal's play, the centuries-old livelihood of Mithila's hereditary bards is archived onstage at the moment of its decline. The spectator witnesses an image of the tradition's living death. The Patna production of 1993 preserves a living example of the bardic tradition even as the bards lament their fate onstage.

5.3 A Parallel with the Revival of Hebrew through Theatre

An important dimension of the history of Israeli theatre is the establishment of Hebrew as the language of a living stage. Habima, founded in Moscow in 1917 and later Israel's national theatre, experimented in Hebrew and helped re-establish it as a language of performance after its long exclusion from everyday theatrical life.

Kunal's drama and its Patna production by the *Bhangima* troupe in 1993 offer a parallel. In a cultural environment dominated by Hindi, staging drama in Maithili is an act of language politics: an effort to affirm Maithili not as "merely a dialect" but as a literary language fit for theatre and its audience. In this respect *Bhangima* played a role analogous to that of Habima.

5.4 Witness Theatre: The Economics of the *Gamchha*

In Israeli theatrical practice, witness theatre, or *edut*, has become an important form in which the stage testifies to a harsh social reality and makes the audience responsible for it.

In the final *gamchha* scene the bards say openly that "our stomachs will be filled only if the spectators show kindness". This is a moment of witnessing. It makes the economic vulnerability of performing artists public and turns the audience into witnesses. The moment is not merely comic: it acknowledges a hard truth of artistic life.

Seen in this way, the ending becomes a political act: an invitation to spectators to become witnesses and accept responsibility.

6. Four-Cornered Synthesis: A Comparative Evaluation

Bringing all four traditions together, *Chalis Chor a Gonu Jha* emerges as a multilayered work. It can be read through Indian *rasa* and *vakrokti*,

Brechtian estrangement, Chinese *xu–shi* and Israeli witness theatre with equal effect.

Indian perspective: an exceptional mixture of *hasya* and *vira rasa*; a folk transformation of the *vidushaka* tradition; the semantic enlargement of "intelligence" through *dhvani*.

Western perspective: a fully Brechtian epic theatre; a classic case of metatheatre; Bakhtinian carnivalesque.

Chinese perspective: the bards' striking likeness to the *chou* role; the aesthetic of *xu–shi*; a *yijing* combining melancholy and exhilaration.

Israeli perspective: Rozik's iconic self-reflection; Levy's theatre-as-archive; language politics comparable to Habima; the witnessing moment of the *gamchha*.

The four traditions share a conclusion: this is not only "Gonu Jha's story" but "the story of theatre" itself—its crisis, economics, life force and social duty. In this sense the play is also a theatrical manifesto, declaring intelligence and the humorous reasoning of folk artists to be powers capable of standing against every obstacle.

Supplementary Socio-Political Reading

Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha, or the Tale of Gyan Jha deconstructs the inherited sense of humour associated with Gonu Jha, the foundational figure of Mithila's clown tradition, and gives it a new intellectual dimension. The transformation from "Gonu Jha" to "Gyan Jha" is not merely a change of name. It signifies the use of intelligence for collective welfare and as an intellectual weapon against social contradictions.

The drama's plot is complex and tied to social reality. It opens with a ploughman's conspiracy against a married couple: by tempting a child with sugar, the ploughman wins the child's claim in his favour and exposes the folly of the supposed wise arbiters, the *panch-parmeshwar*. One of its most important philosophical scenes occurs in Yama's realm. On his deathbed Gonu Jha donates a barren cow in the ritual of *godan*. Upon reaching the other world, Chitragupta looks at Gonu's "account" and says that he is entitled to "lodging" in heaven but not "food", because he donated a barren cow. Gonu cleverly answers this scriptural rebuke by whispering in the cow's ear that Yama and Chitragupta are insulting her for being barren. Enraged, the cow chases both of them, and the terrified Yama finally sends Gonu back to the mortal world. The scene is Kunal's exceptionally sharp, penetrating assault on religious pretension, empty ritual and priestcraft.

Another dimension concerns political and administrative corruption. Bhunbhunadev, the new king of Ghuskiyahi Fort, is exceedingly greedy and cruel. Pretending to mourn his late father, Jhunjhunadev, he appropriates the prizes meant for artists. Through the crooked intelligence of his minister Buriraj, taxes are raised and a conspiracy is eventually laid to rob Gonu Jha's house.

The leadership struggle among the thieves after the death of their chief—the contest between Debaha and Durmatiya—reveals contradictions within the deprived classes. They wager that whoever succeeds in robbing Gonu's house will become the new chief. Gonu defeats both attempts through ingenuity. When Debaha hides in the raised basil shrine in the courtyard, Gonu spits on it, pretending to invoke a "spitting deity", and catches him. When Durmatiya arrives to rob the house with sword and spear, Gonu announces that a bundle of cottonseed, or *bangaur*, is a miraculous medicine called *karpasa-bija-vati*, worth four gold coins per *rati*. The thieves abandon the gold and silver and flee with the packet of seeds.

The play's most important social intervention comes at the end. When the thieves are captured in the imperial court, "Gyan Jha", unlike the traditional Gonu Jha, asks the king not to execute them but to provide them with an adequate means of livelihood and vigilant social protection. Theft, he argues, is a disease whose underlying causes are economic distress and political corruption. This is the stage expression of Kunal's Marxist and socialist consciousness.

63. *Bidapat*: Folk Theatre, History, Memory and the Theatre of Poetry

Abstract

This review of *Bidapat* centres on Vidyapati's poetry, folk-theatrical craftsmanship, historical memory, Lakhima's agency as a heroine, plays within plays, and the immortality of poetry. It examines dramatic structure and cultural significance through Indian theories of *rasa* and *dhvani*, the historical approach to drama, memory studies, Brechtian critical distance, and comparative Chinese and Israeli concepts.

Keywords: *Bidapat*; Vidyapati; folk theatre; memory; Lakhima; *dhvani*; historical drama.

A Clarification of Historical Method

One fundamental distinction is indispensable in this chapter: Vidyapati, the Maithili lyric poet before Jyotirishwar, and Vidyapati Thakkura, the Sanskrit–Avahattha writer of Shiv Singh's era, belong to two different historical persons or traditions. For theatrical purposes, *Bidapat* brings the memories, lyrics, narratives and popular beliefs associated with these two source traditions into a single dramatic world of characters. The combination of Shiv Singh, Lakhima, Ugna and songs from the *padavali* must therefore be understood as the dramatist's creative synthesis, not as proof that the traditions are historically identical or belong to a single person.

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1. Introduction and Dramatic Architecture

Kunal's second play, *Bidapat*—the folk pronunciation of Vidyapati's name—is the most refined work in the collection in terms of its diverse dramatic forms. The playwright explicitly dates this playlet, written in the style of *Bidapat nach*, a celebrated folk-theatrical tradition of Mithila and Bengal, to AD 1400–1450. But his ambition goes further: he does not merely write a biographical play. He creates a theatrical commentary on Vidyapati's poetry.

The play's architecture operates on three levels. The outer level consists of the framing dialogue between *sutradhara* and actress, interruptions by the clown-like Vipta, and the classical performance of the *purvaranga*. The intermediate level stages the events of the plot and its characters—Vidyapati, Shiv Singh, Lakhima, Ugna, Mandakini, Kalindi, Amiyakar

and the courtiers. The inner level consists of embedded performances of Vidyapati's own lyrics, which form the emotional axis of the narrative. The interaction of these three levels generates the theatrical energy of the play.

Five main axes shape the plot: (1) the friendship of Vidyapati and Shiv Singh; (2) Shiv Singh's release from the court of the Sultan of Jaunpur through Vidyapati's poetic powers; (3) the embedded tale of Ugna and Mahadeva; (4) Lakhima's resistance to conspiracy and Shiv Singh's disappearance; and (5) Vidyapati's thirty-two years of mourning and declaration of the immortality of poetry. The triangle of *sutradhara*, actress and Vipta provides the framing conclusion for these five axes.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 *Purvaranga* and the *Dasharupaka* Tradition

Bharata's *Natyashastra* (approximately the second century BCE to the second century CE) requires a *purvaranga*, or preliminary performance, at the opening of a play. This includes the *nandi* or auspicious verse, the entry of the *sutradhara* and the prologue. Kunal not only adopts this classical structure but transforms it into folk-theatrical form. Invocation of the goddess, praise of Bhairavi, and then the *sutradhara*'s introduction: this sequence follows the *Natyashastra*.

From the perspective of the *dasharupaka*, Dhananjaya's tenth-century treatise divides drama into ten kinds. The title page calls *Bidapat* a *natika*, one of the forms of drama, described here as a brief form involving humour, separation and suffering on the part of both hero and heroine. *Bidapat* partly fits this definition: separation and grief are present, but *karuna*, compassion or pathos, takes the place of dominant humour. In explaining *natika*, Abhinavagupta emphasises the need for an exceptional hero. Vidyapati is precisely such a figure.

2.2 The Production of Rasa: The Confluence of Pathos, Love and Tranquillity

The predominant sentiment is *karuna*: Shiv Singh's disappearance, Lakhima's thirty-two-year wait and Vidyapati's final isolation. Bharata identifies the permanent emotion of *karuna rasa* as grief and its determinant as the remembrance of the beloved or the lost. Yet beneath the pathos the play moves towards Abhinavagupta's *shanta rasa*. The concluding choral song, declaring Vidyapati, Shiv Singh, Lakhima and Vipta immortal in poetic verse, expresses the inward repose of tranquillity.

Abhinavagupta (c. 950–1020 CE), in his commentary *Abhinavabharati* on the *Natyashastra*, explains that *rasa* is manifested rather than produced: it

already exists within the spectator's consciousness and is awakened by dramatic performance. *Bidapat* strengthens this manifestation by using Vidyapati's actual lyrics. The spectators' dormant poetic memories awaken through performance.

Shringara rasa flows through Vidyapati's poems, particularly "New Vrindavan, ever-new groves of trees, the young lover wanders" and "Take the essence of the moon to fashion a face". But this is not simply worldly erotic love; it is devotional *shringara* directed towards universal love through the play of Radha and Krishna. Erotic sentiment and devotion thus merge in what Sanskrit poetics understands as a union of love and *bhakti*.

2.3 The Theory of *Dhvani*: Three Meanings Compressed into "Bidapat"

The suggested meaning of the word "Bidapat" is exceptional. From the perspective of Anandavardhana's *Dhvanyaloka*, at least three layers of meaning are compressed in that one word: (a) the dramatic character belonging to Shiv Singh's era, namely Vidyapati Thakkura, the Sanskrit–Avahattha author; (b) the folk tradition of *Bidapat nach*, whose lyric memory is connected with the Vidyapati of the *padavali* before Jyotirishwar; and (c) the folk resonance suggested by the sounds *bida* and *pat*. The drama creatively brings the two historically different Vidyapati traditions together in one stage structure, but the criticism does not mistake that synthesis for historical identity.

Obliqueness in naming—"Vidyapati, Vidyapati!" versus "Bidapat is Bidapat!"—sets the scholarly name against its vernacular pronunciation within the play. The *sutradhara* insists on the classical name; Vipta prefers the popular one. This comic quarrel concerns the naming of a single character within the drama. It does not justify regarding the pre-Jyotirishwar lyric poet and Vidyapati Thakkura, the Sanskrit–Avahattha author of Shiv Singh's era, as one historical person.

2.4 Embedded Drama: The Play Within a Play

Although the *Natyashastra* does not define "embedded drama" as a separate genre, Sanskrit drama contains examples, such as dream scenes in Bhasa's plays and dramatic performance in *Ratnavali*. *Bidapat* contains two such inner dramas. First is Amiyakar's *swang*, a theatrical impersonation in which he enacts Vidyapati's meeting with the sultan; while eating sweets, he moves between roles. This is a vernacular form of acting. Second is the scene involving Gaura, Mahadeva and Natua, where Gaura's lament about Shiva's poverty is performed as a preparation for revealing Ugna as Mahadeva.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Georg Lukács: Historical Drama and the World-Historical Individual

The Hungarian Marxist critic Georg Lukács (1885–1971) advances a criterion for historical drama: the protagonist should be a *welthistorisches Individuum*, a world-historical individual who lives the contradictions of an age within his own person. Vidyapati is such an individual. On one hand, he inhabits a dependent kingdom (Tirhut under Jaunpur); on the other, he believes in a poetic power that transcends politics. His life embodies that contradiction.

Yet Kunal's Vidyapati is not Lukács's "victorious hero". He is a "mourning witness". Shiv Singh's disappearance ends the friendship that had given meaning to the poet's life. The tranquillity attained after thirty-two years of waiting is different from the condition of a Lukácsian tragic hero: this is the tragedy of an Eastern, contemplative protagonist.

3.2 Feminist Reading: Lakhima as Heroine

Western feminist dramatic criticism, including the work of Kate Millett, Elaine Morton and Sharon Friedman, takes particular interest in rereading dramatic texts in which women become secondary figures in the shadow of great historical men. Kunal consciously reverses that tendency.

Lakhima is notable from a feminist perspective for three reasons. First, she rejects ministerial protection and interprets the conspiracy herself: "They are treating this as a golden opportunity to break the trinity of king, queen and great poet." Second, her waiting is not the passivity of conventional wifely fidelity but a freely chosen determination. Third, although traditional narratives often centre Lakhima in a tale of *sati*, Kunal departs from that pattern by making her lived experience of waiting central.

3.3 Pierre Nora: Sites of Memory (*Lieux de Mémoire*)

The French historian Pierre Nora (born 1931), in *Lieux de mémoire*, develops the idea of sites of memory: places, objects and texts in which collective historical memory is stored and made active.

Vidyapati's lyrics are a principal site of memory in this play. When the chorus sings "New Vrindavan, ever-new groves of trees, the young lover wanders", or Lakhima remembers Shiv Singh through the song "O bumblebee, for your sake and mine", the moment belongs simultaneously to historical memory and present experience. Performance brings six centuries of distance into the present instant. Thus *Bidapat* is not merely a

drama about Vidyapati; it is a theatrical enactment of the collective memory of the Maithili-speaking community.

3.4 Brecht and Critical Distance: Vipta's Role

The role performed by the three bards in the first play is taken here by the triangle of *sutradhara*, actress and Vipta. Vipta's repeated insistence that they "move the cart along" is a precise vernacular transformation of Brechtian estrangement. It prevents spectators from becoming wholly submerged in the story and continually reminds them that what they are seeing is a construction.

Yet there is an important difference from Brecht. Brecht sought to awaken the spectators' critical intellect through estrangement. Vipta's interruptions awaken delight rather than intellectual scrutiny. He is a "folk estranger" who brings the elite dignity of art down to the level of the bullock cart and the tale. This aesthetic difference establishes the play's originality in relation to Western dramatic theory.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 *Caizi Jiaren*: The Convention of Poetic Genius and Romance

A major dramatic pattern in classical Chinese theatre, especially the *kunqu* opera of the Ming and Qing periods, is *caizi jiaren*, the "talented scholar and beautiful lady". The romance of a poet-scholar and a beautiful heroine establishes the values of poetic power and love.

Bidapat is a displaced version of this convention. Vidyapati is the *caizi*, distinguished by poetry rather than logical disputation. Lakhima is no ordinary *jiaren* but a self-respecting queen. Their relationship nevertheless contains the deep trust and affectionate friendship at the heart of the convention. Shiv Singh's disappearance transforms it into a triangle: a third person who made their union meaningful is now absent.

4.2 *Zhiyin*: Perfect Understanding and Its Absence

In Chinese culture, *zhiyin*, "one who truly hears or understands", denotes a profound relationship: the person who comprehends an artist's work in all its depth. The famous legend tells how the zither player Bo Ya broke his instrument after the death of his sole *zhiyin*, Zhong Ziqi. "The one who could hear is gone; why should I play?"

The relationship between Vidyapati and Shiv Singh embodies precisely this ideal. Shiv Singh was the supreme listener, connoisseur and patron of Vidyapati's poetry. His disappearance leaves the poet's creative life in a sense orphaned. "Ugna re, where have you gone?" becomes a lament of

separation from the perfect listener. Like Bo Ya's broken zither, the sound of Vidyapati's poems becomes filled with grief.

4.3 *Zhezixi* and Layered Performance

In Chinese folk theatre the tradition of *zhezixi*, the excerpt-play, is well known: a self-contained scene from an extensive epic dramatic cycle is selected for independent performance. Three examples appear clearly in this drama: (a) Amiyakar's impersonation in the sultan's court episode; (b) the inner drama of Gaura, Mahadeva and Natua, anticipating Ugna's revelation; and (c) the Radha-Krishna *rasa* performed by the *sutradhara* and actress in the *purvaranga*.

Layered performance keeps several narrative worlds active simultaneously upon the same stage. Chinese dramatic theory calls this *xizhongxi*, a play within a play. Indian theatre has comparable occasions of performance inside a drama, but the Chinese term provides a more exact vocabulary for analysing its layers.

4.4 *Bei–Huan–Li–He*: Four Fundamental Dramatic States

According to one convention of Chinese theatre, every excellent play should contain four basic emotional states: *bei*, grief; *huan*, delight; *li*, separation; and *he*, reunion. Excellent drama brings them together in one narrative current.

All four occur in *Bidapat*: *huan* in the victory at Oini and the celebrations; *li* in Shiv Singh's disappearance; *bei* in Vidyapati and Lakhima's thirty-two years of mourning; and *he* in reunion through poetry—a spiritual, invisible reunion in which Vidyapati proclaims Shiv Singh immortal in his verses. This reunion is not earthly but inward. It thereby transcends the Chinese ideal and opens another possibility.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 S. Ansky's *The Dybbuk*: The Theatrical Presence of Dead Love

The Jewish-Russian dramatist S. Ansky (1863–1920) wrote *The Dybbuk* (*Between Two Worlds*, 1920), regarded as a foundational text of Hebrew and Yiddish theatre. A dead lover's spirit enters the body of his beloved and gains a theatrical presence. Love is stronger than death: that is its central proposition.

In *Bidapat*, Shiv Singh disappears physically from the stage, yet his presence in Lakhima's memory becomes a theatrical existence resembling a *dybbuk*. When his shadow appears as the song "O bumblebee, for your sake and mine" is sung, the moment follows a theatrical logic akin to that

of *The Dybbuk*. In both works the emotional truth of love breaks through the boundary of death.

5.2 Eli Rozik: The Iconic Existence of the Poetic Lyric

In his theory of iconicity, Eli Rozik argues that theatrical images arise not only through the actor's body but also through sound. When the *samaji* chorus sings Vidyapati's lyrics, the song becomes a "sound-icon", not simply music but a theatrical image of Vidyapati's entire world of life.

One distinction made by Rozik is particularly relevant: the difference between the theatrical image and the dramatic text. Kunal's written playlet and the stage image made by the singing actor's integrated body, voice and movement are independent entities. In this drama they exist in a particular tension: Kunal's text incorporates Vidyapati's songs, but those songs continually exceed the text's control and live their own independent poetic life.

5.3 Beyond Habima's Language Politics: The Rebirth of Poetic Language

In the discussion of the preceding play we saw the parallel between Habima Theatre and the language politics of *Bhangima*. In *Bidapat* this parallel acquires another dimension: not only the life of a language but the life of poetic language. The continuation of Habima's tradition in Israel is also connected with attempts to keep Hebrew poetry alive onstage.

The 2002 Patna performance of *Bidapat* at Vidyapati Bhavan revived Vidyapati's lyrics through theatre at a time when they were increasingly becoming objects confined to libraries. In that sense the production by *Bhangima* is a "theatrical rebirth of poetic language", parallel to the revival of Hebrew poetry in Israeli performance.

5.4 A Postcolonial Perspective: The Diplomatic Power of Poetry

Within postcolonial theatre studies associated with the Israeli scholar Avraham Oz and others, particular importance is given to theatrical acts in which cultural power defeats political or military power.

The sultan's court episode in *Bidapat* is exemplary in this respect. The Sultan of Jaunpur represents political power; Vidyapati represents cultural power. He secures Shiv Singh's release not through diplomacy in the conventional sense but through a poetic performance: while blindfolded, he composes a lyric depicting a bathing scene. Asked by the sultan to name his reward, Vidyapati demands his friend's freedom, not a throne. A minister remarks, "He could have asked for the kingdom of Tirhut!" Vidyapati replies, "But I have indeed obtained a kingdom!" This is a postcolonial declaration of victory through poetic power.

6. Four-Cornered Synthesis

Bringing together the four traditions clarifies the central question of *Bidapat*: what is poetic power, and in what forms does it establish its existence? Each tradition offers a different angle of approach.

Indian perspective: poetic power is the manifestation of *rasa*. The lyrics express an already existing sentiment. At the culmination of *shanta rasa*, poetry becomes a conqueror of death.

Western perspective: poetic power is a site of memory in Nora's sense, an expression of the world-historical individual in Lukács's sense, and a feminist rereading centred upon Lakhima.

Chinese perspective: poetic power is the art of perfect understanding, or *zhiyin*, and of the spiritual reunion reached through *bei–huan–li–he*.

Israeli perspective: poetic power is the independent existence of a sound-icon in Rozik's sense and a cultural-diplomatic victory over colonial power through poetry.

All four perspectives agree on one point: Vidyapati's lyrics are not merely literary works but a living cultural and political force. Kunal revivifies that force through theatre. In this sense *Bidapat* is not simply a play about Vidyapati: it is a declaration of Maithili theatre's own existence.

Next: *Kusma-Salhes*

Supplementary Historical and Social Analysis

The play *Bidapat* is composed on the structural foundation of the famous Maithili folk-theatrical form of the same name. It releases the great poet Vidyapati from the narrow confines of courtly culture and establishes him as a people's poet and a protagonist of popular struggle.

The *purvaranga* opens with praise of Shiva and a dance to Bhairavi, placing the dramatic period between AD 1350 and 1450. The first scene depicts festivities in the capital after King Shiv Singh's victory at Oini, where Pamariya performers and bards sing his praises. Yet orthodox Sanskrit pundits, identified as Pandit One and Pandit Two, strongly oppose the *nachari* and *maheshvani* songs composed by Vidyapati in the vernacular, Maithili. Because these songs describe Mahadeva as "naked, a beggar since birth", they conspire to brand Vidyapati obscene and a disgrace to society. Fundamentally, this conflict is a class struggle between a priestly group defending the dominance of the "language of the gods" and the ordinary people's *desil vayna*, speech of the land.

The second scene gives a delicate portrayal of courtly and personal relations. Vidyapati dedicates his new Avahattha poem *Kirtilata*, the story

of the defeat of Gaudesh Yadusena, to the young prince Shiv Singh. Here he is not merely a poet; he also becomes an emotional bridge between Shiv Singh and Queen Lakhima, resolving the alienation and conflict in their marriage through the song "Sarasija binu sara …".

The third scene portrays political intrigue and the exploitation of the people. The royal tax collectors mercilessly beat the peasants with canes while extracting revenue. Vidyapati insists upon freeing the afflicted peasants from their grasp. In revenge, the Sanskrit-dominant pundit Chandrakar and his associates conspire to issue a secret invitation to Sultan Ibrahim Shah of Jaunpur to send his army against Tirhut, hoping that the rebellious prince Shiv Singh will be imprisoned and the supremacy of Sanskrit restored. The scene exposes the internal treachery of feudalism and its hostility to the people.

64. Limitations, Shortcomings and Intellectual Tensions in the Seven Plays

Abstract

Criticism is not merely appreciative evaluation. This chapter therefore examines structural inconsistencies across the seven plays, character development, the repetition of metatheatre, reliance upon announcers, tensions between women's agency and patriarchal validation, divine intervention, the formation of titles, stage directions and dramatic economy. The objective is not to diminish the works' value but to clarify possible improvements for their future reading and performance.

Keywords: criticism of limitations; structure; character development; announcer; female agency; stage directions; dramatic economy.

Introduction: Why Criticism Is Necessary

Balanced literary evaluation cannot be completed through praise alone. Kunal's *Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays* is a notable collection of Maithili drama. That is evident from the fact that all seven plays were staged repeatedly, published in *Bhangima* and *Antika*, and finally brought together in book form. Yet this very commitment makes the reader and critic responsible: the greater a play's achievement, the more candidly must its limitations be acknowledged.

The purpose of examining the weaknesses, intellectual tensions, formal limitations and defects of repetition in all seven plays is not to dismiss the works but to offer a constructive perspective for future playwriting.

Structural Limitations: Unequal Scale and a Disrupted Rhythm

The collection's most obvious structural problem is the disparity in the lengths of its seven plays. *Kusma-Salhes* is a vast drama of about seventy pages; *Prem-Pratijna urf Shruvavatik Jai!* ends in only fourteen. When a reader or future director moves from *Kusma-Salhes* to *Shruvavati*, the transition is suddenly from an epic world to a short chamber piece. It is not a comfortable shift.

Consider the comparison:

Chalis Chor a Gonu Jha: 74 pages; *Bidapat*: 48 pages; *Kusma-Salhes*: 70 pages; *Shruvavati*: 14 pages; *Sukanya*: 26 pages; *Shweta*: 18 pages; *Suprabha–Ashtavakra*: 28 pages.

The first three plays average sixty-four pages, while the final four average twenty-one. This is a problem of book architecture. They seem like the

contents of two different books; placing them in one volume produces an awkward reading rhythm.

The Uniformity of the "Or" Formula in the Titles

All four titles in the quartet of love follow the same pattern: "[abstract emotion] or [the heroine's name] and [a word signifying action]". It feels fresh in the first three plays, combining a classical emotion with a popular announcement; by the fourth repetition it becomes mechanical. The reader recognises the "formula" as soon as the title is read, and surprise vanishes.

Compare *Bidapat*, one word dense with many meanings, and *Kusma-Salhes*, two character names suggesting an epic scope. Each title carries the living energy of its play. *Premak Vistar urf Shwetak Avishkar* is relatively formal and formulaic. The repetitive progression of titles is a limitation of the quartet of love.

Weaknesses and Intellectual Tensions in Individual Plays

Chalis Chor a Gonu Jha

(a) Excessive Metatheatre

The play's metatheatrical devices—the bards' debate, alternative endings and addresses to spectators—are admirable as dramatic craft. Yet in the final scene, when the bards announce that "theft is a social disease born of illiteracy and poverty", the message becomes something merely "told". By the criterion attributed to Bharata—that drama "shows" rather than "tells"—the ending is weak. The message should emerge from the action itself; an explicit explanation by the bards is unnecessary.

(b) Two-Dimensional Thieves

Compared with Gonu Jha, the forty thieves, especially Durmatiya and Debaha, remain little more than comic devices. The poverty and lack of education that the playwright himself recognises at the end as a "social disease" are never given dramatic depth. There is a contradiction here: the playwright offers a progressive social explanation in his conclusion, yet throughout the play the thieves remain objects of ridicule. Socially realistic drama would resolve the contradiction by humanising the thieves' poverty in at least one scene.

(c) The Double Meaning of the *Gamchha* Episode

The scene in which performers spread a cloth and ask for donations has two functions simultaneously: Brechtian transparency, revealing the economic vulnerability of artists, and a criticism of state patronage of the arts. But neither meaning is fully developed. The episode appears more like

a mechanical repetition of a folk convention than a deliberate dramatic choice.

Bidapat

(a) Vipta's "Move the Cart Along": From Humour to Interruption

Vipta's refrain, "Move the cart along", is at first a fresh folk-theatrical device. Yet it occurs so frequently that, instead of producing a Brechtian estrangement effect, it becomes a mechanical interruption. Once spectators know that Vipta will say it again and again, the element of surprise disappears. Brechtian estrangement works best when unexpected; here it becomes entirely predictable.

(b) The Incomplete Ugna–Mahadeva Episode

The revelation that Ugna was really Mahadeva should constitute a central emotional moment in the famous folk tale. In this play, however, the discovery of Ugna's divine identity reaches us through another character's report—Amiyakar's account—rather than through direct dramatic action. Consequently, the moment cannot fully release its emotional potential, which in Vidyapati devotion is a moment of divine revelation.

(c) The Tension Between History and Poetry

The play announces an "historical" period from AD 1400 to 1450, but its dramatic structure is poetic and folk-theatrical throughout. The tension between the two sometimes becomes visible. For instance, the sultan's court represents a historical reality, yet presenting it through Amiyakar's comic impersonation lightens its historical gravity. The playwright's balance between history and poetry occasionally wavers.

Kusma-Salhes

(a) One-Dimensional Villains: Suchong and Chuhar

In the anthology's most ambitious play, the villains become one-dimensional. Suchong, Chuharmall and Tarumall are merely accumulations of evil traits, without inner conflict or human complexity. When they torture Budhesar, their communal laughter—"Ho … ho …"—makes their cruelty superficial. In epic drama, the finest villain compels the audience to understand, perhaps even temporarily to share, his perspective. Such complexity is absent here.

(b) Geographical Expansion at the Expense of Dramatic Focus

The play changes locations too often: Mahisoutha, Morang, Bhot, Baghgarh, Samdagarh, Rewa-Dah and Rangilagarh. This geographical expanse confirms the authenticity of the epic narrative, but as drama it

pushes the central love story of Kusma and Salhes into the background. The war involving the king of Morang and the account of Bhot's invasion keep Kusma offstage for a considerable time. The balance between epic scope and theatrical focus is not wholly achieved.

(c) Syncretic Invocation and Cultural Dissonance

The invocation of Mira-Sultan at the opening is a beautiful syncretic gesture. Yet placing the specific cultural elements of the Dusadh Salhes tradition—forest goddess, animal companions, and its distinctive folk terminology—alongside "Jana Gana Mana" seems somewhat incongruous. Syncretism is an admirable goal, but here its reach makes the invocation resemble a display of universal religious harmony more than an authentic Dusadh religious appeal.

Prem-Pratijna urf Shruvavatik Jai!

(a) Entering the Fire: A Structural Tension with the Feminist Reading

The play's gravest intellectual tension is that Shruvavati declares herself an "independent and self-reliant person" yet, when the fruit fails to cook, resolves to "enter the fire while remembering the beloved". The play treats her entry into the fire as an expression of "inner strength", but the sacrificial image itself follows a patriarchal convention. A free woman demands life, not death. The contradiction remains unresolved.

Compare Sukanya in the fifth play, who takes responsibility for the consequences of her father's curse and chooses a course of life, or Ashtavakra in the seventh, who rejects Urvashi and chooses living love. Beside them, Shruvavati's resolve to enter the pyre is a weaker dramatic resolution.

(b) Indra's Three Disguises: Repetition and Loss of Credibility

Indra first appears openly and introduces himself, then as an old man, and finally as Vasishtha. The three appearances repeat the same structure—Shruvavati rejects him each time—creating an increasingly predictable dramatic rhythm. The third encounter, as Vasishtha, is essentially a repetition of the second, as the old man. She rejects him in both; he becomes angry in both. Instead of increasing tension, repetition diminishes it.

(c) Dushyant Kumar's Urdu Couplet: The Difficulty of an Imported Element

The concluding Hindi–Urdu couplet by Dushyant Kumar, "Who says that a hole cannot be made in the sky?", contributes cultural and linguistic richness. But within a mythological Maithili playlet it also feels somewhat

out of place. If a poetic line was necessary, the Maithili poetic tradition could have supplied a comparable verse. This is a small yet particular problem of form.

Vishwask Shakti urf Sukanyak Vivah

(a) Difference in Age and Ethical Discomfort

The play itself acknowledges this tension through a choral song: "A daughter sixteen years old, and Chyavana's age a thousand." The song gives amusing expression to the ethical discomfort of the age difference without resolving it. Chyavana is confident of his age and abilities, the king gives his assent out of helplessness, and Sukanya willingly accepts. Yet the ethical basis of that consent is not sufficiently developed.

(b) Excessive Length of the Ashvini Kumars' Episode

The first arrival of the Ashvini Kumars, their reappearance, apology, comparison with Urvashi, threat of a curse, renewed meeting, and episode of *soma-rasa* occupy a large part of the play. The main story of love—the developing relationship between Sukanya and Chyavana—receives comparatively little space. In terms of dramatic economy, removing one Ashvini scene and expanding the central couple's relationship would have produced a better balance.

(c) The "Chyavanprash" Remark: The Risk of a Temporal Rift

The announcer's reference to "Chyavana of Chyavanprash" is humorous for a moment. Yet this reference to modern consumer culture creates a temporal rift in the mythological setting. If the intrusion was deliberate, a Brechtian estrangement effect, its dramatic purpose should have been applied more consistently throughout the play.

Premak Vistar urf Shwetak Avishkar

(a) Atiratha's Transformation: A Problem of Dramatic Motivation

The play's gravest formal limitation is the excessive speed of Atiratha's psychological transformation. On the one hand, he is portrayed as a king detached for "seven or eight years", a man who returns alone from every marriage-selection assembly. On the other, as soon as he hears of Shweta's water burial, he races to the riverbank and removes his crown upon meeting her in the forest. Years of detachment dissolve within a single scene. The transformation lacks sufficient psychological groundwork.

"Atiratha became dispirited", "everything seemed artificial", "everything seemed like lifeless puppets": these pronouncements by the announcer tell us why Atiratha changes. But this is telling, not showing.

In Ibsen's *Hedda Gabler* and Chekhov's *Three Sisters*, psychological transformation is established gradually, scene by scene. In *Shwetak Avishkar*, the arc of Atiratha's change depends too heavily on the announcer's description and too little upon direct theatrical action.

(b) Lack of a Source Narrative

The story of Shweta and Atiratha has no known mythological or historical source: it is wholly Kunal's invention. That is a strength in itself, a mark of originality. But it also leads to a weakness: this story lacks the narrative weight and credibility that a mythological source supplies to the other six plays. The royal dancer and the detached king are a familiar dramatic trope already used in several Indian languages.

Premak Pariksha urf Suprabha a Ashtavakra

(a) Vadanya's Motivation: An Unexplained Refusal

The real reason for the sage Vadanya's rejection of Ashtavakra is never made clear. He says, "I am not obliged to offer an explanation." The dramatist employs this "mystery" as a device, but it leaves Vadanya psychologically hollow. Because the grounds of rejection remain unknown, spectators cannot fully understand what is at stake in the trial. Vadanya becomes a functional agent of the plot rather than a living character.

(b) Suprabha's Uneven Presence on Stage

In the title Suprabha's name comes before Ashtavakra's, yet the first half of the play is devoted to Ashtavakra. Suprabha appears only in the tenth and eleventh scenes of twelve; she is absent from the twelfth, concerning Urvashi. If the title accords priority to Suprabha, the dramatic structure fails to reflect that priority.

(c) The Secret of Vandi: A Lost Dramatic Opportunity

Vandi is in fact Varuna's son, and "water burial" means that scholars were being kept under the water god's protection for a sacrifice. This secret is the play's most surprising plot twist. Yet the playwright reduces the revelation to a comic passage ("Water is my home and hearth"). Had it become a full theatrical disclosure, it could have been one of the drama's finest scenes.

Limitations Shared by the Collection

Female Agency and the Sequence of Patriarchal Approval

All four dramas in the quartet of love share a structural feature that is also a shared limitation: every heroine's independent choice ultimately receives completion through the "approval of male authority".

Shruvavati's victory is validated by Indra's announcement, "You have won"; Sukanya's marriage by the assent of King Sharyati and Chyavana; Shweta's liberation by Atiratha's departure and pursuit; and Suprabha's marriage by Vadanya's permission. These four examples show that the dramatist makes the heroine an agent, yet the final confirmation of her victory comes from a male character. This subtle reproduction of patriarchal structures somewhat limits the playwright's feminist ideas.

Dependence on the Announcer: "Telling" versus "Showing"

All four dramas in the quartet assign the announcer, or narrator, the role of interpreter of emotions:

"Shweta's depression vanished ..."; "Atiratha grew dispirited ..."; "The night passed as though an age were passing ...".

At times such explanations deprive the characters of a dramatic opportunity to express their feelings themselves. Theatre reaches its strongest emotional moments when characters live through an experience rather than having a narrator tell us about it. Dependence on the announcer is a broad formal limitation of these plays.

The Intellectual Contradiction of Divine Intervention

Several plays in the collection make lofty declarations about female agency, yet a deity or supernatural power intervenes to resolve the action.

Shruvavati's "inner strength" is "proved" by Indra's recognition; Sukanya's "trust" is rewarded with Chyavana's renewed youth through the Ashvini Kumars' medicinal knowledge; and Ashtavakra's paternal curse is lifted by bathing in a river. This sequence of divine rewards produces an unintended message: fidelity in love inevitably wins supernatural recompense. Human agency is thus validated as dependent upon fate rather than as autonomous.

Vidyapati's Lyrics: The Risk of Overuse

Vidyapati's poems are used in both *Bidapat* and *Sukanya*. In *Bidapat* their use is entirely fitting and coherent: Vidyapati is the central protagonist. But in *Sukanya* the spring song "The lord of seasons, King Spring, has arrived" serves to create atmosphere. This raises a question: does the collection have some programme of preserving Vidyapati's lyrics? If another poem from the Maithili tradition were used for the spring setting in *Sukanya*, Vidyapati's songs in *Bidapat* would become even more distinctive.

Stage Directions: Uneven Levels of Detail

Stage directions in the folk-theatrical trilogy are extensive and specific: "Singing, Kusma the gardener, Thanka-Banka … Kunta, tenderly fondling Budhesar". By contrast, the quartet of love often uses minimal directions: "Change of lighting", "Music", "Freeze". This difference reflects two periods in the dramatist's compositional practice, but it also means that the shorter playlets give performers less guidance.

Conclusion: Possibility Alongside Limitations

First, the prominence of explicit messages sometimes replaces dramatic tension in the quartet of love. In particular, concluding couplets and comments by announcers occasionally state outright what would have been more powerful if left to suggestion. The heart of theatre is showing, not announcing; by that standard the folk-theatrical trilogy is stronger than the quartet of love. Second, the use of the convention of entering the fire in *Shruvavati's Victory!* creates an intellectual tension with its forceful argument for women's freedom. Although the play seeks to portray it as a resolution expressing inner strength, the sacrificial symbol does not wholly accord with a contemporary feminist reading; the question remains open. Third, the collection shows a difference in scale: epic dramas such as *Kusma-Salhes* are placed alongside chamber playlets in the quartet of love. In one sense this variety is a source of richness, but it also disrupts the rhythm of reading. Even after recognising these limits, one must admit that they remain secondary beside the central strength of Kunal's theatrical vision: performability and communication with ordinary audiences.

The collection's limitations can be grouped chiefly in three categories:

(a) Formal limitations: dependence on the announcer, telling rather than showing, and the flatness of certain characters.

(b) Intellectual tensions: the convention of entering the fire, patriarchal approval, and dependence on divine rewards.

(c) Structural limitations: unequal scale, uniformity of titles and repeated dramatic formulae.

Crucially, these limitations do not destroy the collection's value. No body of writing is without weaknesses. Even the great poet Vidyapati repeats conventional patterns of heroines; Bhikhari Thakur's plays, too, contain linguistic inconsistencies. Kunal's limitations frequently occur precisely where his ambition takes its highest flight. That is a sign of a living creative writer.

Identifying such limitations also has a practical purpose: future directors can address them in performance. A perceptive director could expand Atiratha's journey of transformation through silent scenes; Shruvavati's

decision to enter the fire could be restaged as a declaration of strength; and the revelation of Vandi's secret could become an immense theatrical moment. This is the quality of living theatre: each production is a new "version".

65. Overall Conclusion: The Intellectual Unity of Kunal's Dramatic World

Abstract

This concluding chapter brings together the collection's folk-theatrical trilogy and quartet of love as successive developments of intelligence, the immortality of poetry, fearlessness, faith, self-determination and love. Fidelity to folk sources, a synthesis of classical learning, popular tradition and modernity, social sensitivity, and practical theatricality emerge as the common foundations of Kunal's dramatic work.

Keywords: Kunal; Maithili theatre; folk drama; love; intelligence; female agency; synthesis.

Conclusion

Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays is an important contribution to contemporary Maithili theatre. It is a bridge between folk drama and the modern stage, one that not only preserves Mithila's tradition of *nach* but also revives it by filling it with contemporary thought. The collection stands on four pillars: intelligence in *Chalis Chor*, the immortality of poetry in *Bidapat*, freedom from fear and love in *Kusma-Salhes*, and women's agency in the quartet of love. Ultimately these pillars lead towards a single thesis: love, understood as broad human compassion and an attachment to life, is the fundamental principle of creation, while intelligence is its guardian.

Through its fidelity to folk sources, its sensitivity to subaltern and women's voices, its synthesis of classical learning, popular forms and modernity, and its practical knowledge of the stage, this collection exemplifies the parallel-literary perspective of *Videha*. It also constitutes an essential point of reference for Maithili dramatic criticism. Study, teaching and renewed performance of these works are equally necessary for the vitality of Maithili theatre.

Kunal's *Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays* opens a new highway in the development of Maithili dramatic literature. Drawing upon his long theatrical experience, Kunal has demonstrated that no art can survive by imitating the past alone. Continuous renewal and contemporary relevance are essential.

The way these seven plays establish Mithila's traditional folk culture, the voice of Dalit resistance, the deconstruction of mythological narratives and women's identities upon the stage enriches Maithili literature immeasurably and gives it cause for pride. Kunal's renewed use of the

kirtaniya, *Bidapat* and *Pamariya* forms gives direction to the next generation of theatre workers. Ultimately the anthology effects an intimate yet reasoned reconciliation between classical dramatic vision and folk life, restoring theatre as one of society's sharpest intellectual instruments.

66. Mahendra Malangia's Chhutahar / Chhutahar Ghail / Chhutha Ghail

Abstract

Chhutha Ghail is the title of Mahendra Malangia's new play. He has written a ten-page preface to this short play. He is distressed that Ramanand Jha 'Raman' suggested that 'Chhutahar Ghail' should simply be called 'Chhutahar'.

Keywords: Mahendra Malangia; Chhutha Ghail; drama; vernacular speech; caste; stageability; arrangement of scenes.

Chhutha Ghail is the name of Mahendra Malangia's new play. He has written a preface of ten pages to this short drama.

Let us begin with that preface. He is aggrieved that Ramanand Jha 'Raman' suggested calling 'Chhutahar Ghail' simply 'Chhutahar'. In response, he advances three points. First:

'You speak sometimes of what is written in books;

I speak sometimes of what my own eyes have seen.'

Second, a lamenting poem by Yatri:

'I remain off to one side, like a ghail chhutahar;

Alas, how grievously unfortunate I am!'

He then asks what connection the widow in that poem and Kabutari Devi in this play have with Shiva's Maheshvara Sutras and Panini's ten lakaras (Panini specified twelve lakaras for Vedic Sanskrit and ten for classical Sanskrit … but let that pass).

Third, he likens his own position to that of Copernicus: what difference does it make what people say, when in villages and households people actually use the expression 'Chhutahar Ghail'!

Yet on all three points Malangia's arguments work against him. Both the evidence of 'what the eyes have seen' and actual popular usage show that people say simply 'Chhutahar'. Can one place a chhutahar on a ghailchi? When betel leaves are laid out in a loita to grow, would Malangia's reasoning require us to call it a 'Loita Ghail'? Ghail, surahi, koha, taula, chhutahar, loita, khapari, kurni, kurwar, kosiya, sarba and sobarna are all distinct objects with distinct names. In accepting a suggestion by Phoolchandra Mishra 'Raman'—who probably proposed 'Chhutha Ghail' jokingly; if he did not, it is a newly coined expression in a new language!—

Malangia changed 'Chhutahar Ghail' into 'Chhutha Ghail'. This indicates that he had realised the mistake but did not wish to appear diminished by accepting Ramanand Jha 'Raman's' point. Instead he planted his own stake. Later Ramanand Jha 'Raman' asked the Chetana Samiti to publish the book; the committee would provide only twenty-five copies, so Malangia had it published by his own organisation. What concern are these matters of the reader's? Now consider Yatri's example. Yatri also had to keep Hindi readers in mind. He sometimes could not even remember which of his poems were in Hindi, which in Maithili and which in both. Thus he wrote 'Chhutahar Ghail'. One can also see the reason in Yatri's wish to secure a rhyme. And now to Copernicus: even if Yatri or Malangia writes 'Ghail Chhutahar', 'Chhutahar Ghail' or 'Chhutha Ghail', will native speakers of Maithili begin calling the chhutahar by any of these expressions? The Copernicus example therefore works against Malangia too.

Malangia has been unable to employ the Copernicus legend correctly. Perhaps he is confusing Copernicus with Galileo. Copernicus's theory received the support of the Pope, and Copernicus dedicated his forty-page manuscript on heliocentrism to Pope Paul III. But Malangia's unfamiliarity with science, and his tendency to attach scientific theories to legends, will not surprise you when you encounter in this very preface his ignorance of genuine folk narratives.

'Ali Baba and the Forty Thieves': the entire world knows this as a medieval Arabic folk tale included in the Arabian Nights (the Thousand and One Tales). There is a dispute over whether it was inserted into the Arabian Nights later, but there is no dispute that it is a medieval Arabic folk tale. The things Malangia goes on to say about Balban's atrocities and similar matters, from a communal perspective, reveal only a superficial attachment to folklore. The shallow knowledge of the panji system found in Mithila Tattva Vimarsha or in Ramanath Jha's account was superseded long ago; the matter is recorded in our genealogical books in written form. Gonu Jha lived three hundred years before Vidyapati, but Malangia proceeds on the basis of stories circulating fifty years ago. He knows that Gonu was called Dhurtacharya, but does not know that Gonu was also called Mahamahopadhyaya! In Gonu Jha's time, Muslims did not live in Mithila; where, then, could a 'tahsildar's beard' have come from? The people say 'chhutahar'; change it to 'chhutha ghail'. The folk tale speaks of the beard of a tax collector; call it a 'tahsildar's' beard and on communal grounds pronounce Muslims oppressors. Then write a preface so intimidating that Ramanand Jha 'Raman' and others will be afraid to review it. The Satnami rebellion, which began in a quarrel between a foot soldier and a Satnami—a member of a progressive sect founded by Dalit and backward communities—was directed against Aurangzeb's policies,

and a mosque was also burnt in its course. But Gonu Jha's tax-collection officer was not Muslim: that is not in the folk tale. If a communal storyteller has inserted his ideology into a narrated story and then acted dishonestly in writing it down, what has that to do with Maithili folklore? This is what happens if folk tales are not collected through fieldwork.

Mahendra Narayan Ram writes that folk tales do not observe caste distinctions; but how could Malangia accept that? Bhagat too is bound to appear in his narrative. The real reason he becomes an inseparable part of Malangia's play, however, is the dramatist's inherited belief in caste superiority. The drama has seventeen scenes, each roughly two and a half pages long. Until the fifteenth scene Malangia follows his old practice of inviting upper-caste spectators to laugh at the alleged speech of the 'lower castes'—a language of his own invention—and of creating a spurious humour through Bhagat's broken Hindi. Only from the sixteenth scene does he attempt to give the story a purpose, but by then the opportunity has slipped from his grasp. At a time when Prakrit or any other secondary language is no longer used in Sanskrit drama, Malangia's introduction of Bharata in an inappropriate context reveals his unfamiliarity with Sanskrit. It indicates reliance on secondary Hindi-language books about the Natyashastra rather than study of the original text.

Does Malangia mean that a play which is good to read cannot be fit for performance, or that a play written for the stage cannot be good to read? That is certainly the impression given by the Sanskrit line he quotes. If a drama does not stir its reader, how is a director to decide to stage it? And what precisely are its theatrical qualities: seventeen scenes of approximately two and a half pages each; a casteist idiom humiliating the so-called lower class; Bhagat's Hindi formula 'Samajhta hai ki nahin?' ('Do you understand or not?'); and the 'slapstick humour' allegedly produced by combining them? Anyone who opposes this and proposes a parallel Maithili theatre becomes, in this argument, merely a champion of the readable elements of drama, while the conservative casteist is represented as the champion of its theatrical elements! Would Malangia's caste-based sentence construction be acceptable in a twenty-first-century play in Sanskrit, Hindi or any modern Indian language other than Maithili? If not, why does a playwright who has not read Bharata's original Sanskrit Natyashastra repeatedly use irrelevant facts about Sanskrit drama eighteen hundred years old as a shield for this vocabulary? Does carrying a basket on one's head and a child at one's side necessarily mark someone as belonging to a lower class? In his Barahmasa of the courtyard he calls this class 'rad'; after several decades he has at least advanced to calling it the 'lower class'. The improvement is welcome, but very small for so long a period. How did Babaji enter the story, how did ganja enter it, and what relation does that have to the trees in the orchard? How could Malangia have smuggled in his

caste-based syntax and broken-Hindi expressions without introducing Bhagat and the fictitious concept of the lower class? He tries very cleverly to conceal this fact, and consequently cannot rise above mediocrity. He therefore wishes to give his dramatic narrative a purpose but has not acquired the capacity to do so.

Authors, Special Issues, Institutions and Social Debates

67. Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar (1891–1956)

Abstract

Ramji Sakpal's family came from that village. He was the headmaster of a school in the Indian Army. Gaurangi, Nilakshi and Bhima were his wives. His fourteenth child was born to Bhima on 14 April 1891 and named Bhim. Ramji was then posted at Mhow ...

Keywords: Dr; Babasaheb; Ambedkar; 1891; 1956; literary criticism; Maithili.

Summary · Abstract

This chapter presents a dramatic-critical study on "Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar (1891–1956)". Babasaheb, Ambedkar, 1891, 1956 and Bhim emerge as principal points of focus in the discussion. On the basis of the examples, quotations and arguments available in the original material, the dramatic text, the configuration of characters, the structure of performance and the cultural context are examined, so that readers may understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

1

Ratnagiri is a town in Maharashtra. Near it is the village of Ambavade.

Ramji Sakpal's family came from that village. He was the headmaster of a school in the Indian Army. Gaurangi, Nilakshi and Bhima were his wives. His fourteenth child was born to Bhima on 14 April 1891 and named Bhim. Ramji was then posted at Mhow.

In 1894 Ramji retired from service. Bhim's mother died when he was only six years old, after which his disabled elder sister brought him up. His father married again and went to Goregaon in search of work.

2

Ramji Sakpal belonged to the Mahar community, treated as untouchable. He would wake Bhim early in the morning to study by reciting Kabir's couplets to him.

When, after retiring, he came to Kap-Dapoli in 1894, the education department of the Dapoli municipality decided not to admit untouchable children to its schools. Until then such children had been enrolled in them. Ramji therefore went to Mumbai and then to Satara. Bhim received his elementary education in Satara.

No barber would cut Bhim's hair, so his sister cut it for him.

No one would sit next to him at school.

A bullock-cart driver agreed to carry him only on condition that Bhim himself drove the cart while the driver sat at ease.

Even drinking water was a crisis: were the reservoirs not for him?

'I will acquire an education; then all these things will become available to me.' Bhim made this resolution.

There were two teachers at the school, Pendse and Ambedkar.

One day Bhim deliberately soaked himself so that he would not have to attend school. Pendse, however, sent him home, and he had to put on a dhoti and return to his lessons.

Bhim became Ambedkar's most beloved pupil. Ambedkar was a Brahmin. One day Bhim had brought no food and was sitting alone beneath a tree, hungry.

Ambedkar asked, 'Bhim, why are you sitting here by yourself?' Bhim said that he had not brought any food that day. 'So what?' Ambedkar replied. 'Come, today teacher and pupil will eat roti and vegetables together.' No one had ever treated Bhim with such kindness. He was overjoyed.

Ambedkar said, 'Bhim, I give you my family name. From now on you will be called Ambedkar.'

3

Ramji came to Mumbai. Bhim was admitted to Elphinstone School, completing his school education in 1907. Keluskar gave him the Buddhacharitam as a gift.

Bhim very much wanted to study Sanskrit at school, but he was not permitted to do so.

When Bhim was seventeen, he married Rama, who was nine years old.

Through Keluskar's efforts Bhim obtained a scholarship from the ruler of Baroda, and in 1912 he passed the BA examination.

The Baroda government appointed him to the rank of lieutenant.

After that, however, his father fell ill. Bhim came to see him, and his father was happy. Amid that happiness his father passed away. Such is death's play; Bhim wept aloud.

4

With the ruler of Baroda's scholarship, Bhim left for New York in 1913 to pursue his studies. Columbia University accepted his dissertation and awarded him the degree of Doctor of Philosophy.

Bhim returned.

His well-wishers decided that he should be honoured—honoured on a grand scale.

But he refused the felicitation. 'Use the money that would be spent on honouring me to provide scholarships. Educate the deprived.'

The ruler of Baroda summoned him to Baroda and directed that accommodation and meals be arranged for him.

Yet no eating house or lodging house was willing to receive him. A Parsi establishment sheltered him for a few days but then expelled him.

He began to weep beneath a tree. 'I had thought that by acquiring an education I would overcome what others called my defects. But now I am educated: why am I still being subjected to this torment? I resolve to break this system and strike at its roots.'

5

Bhim returned to Mumbai and became a professor at Sydenham College.

Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj of Kolhapur was committed to the uplift of marginalised people. Bhim went there. At Mangaon, Shahu Maharaj declared, 'People who have been neglected, your liberator has arrived—Dr Ambedkar.'

Then came another blow. After the death of their son Gangadhar, his wife Rama sank into sorrow. She continued to raise Yashwant. Her husband gave very little time to the family, but she bore everything.

6

Leaving his teaching post, he submitted a dissertation on 'The Problem of the Rupee' to a London institution named 'Economic and Political Science'. He was regarded as a revolutionary, however; he therefore submitted a revised thesis to the institution's satisfaction and returned with the degree of Doctor of Science. After studying law he also began to practise in court.

On 20 July 1924 he founded the Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha ('Association for the Welfare of the Excluded'). He had come to believe that people must solve their own problems; others could not solve them for them.

On 20 March 1927 he led a people's movement at Mahad, where all drank water from the Chavdar Talav reservoir.

Thereafter he disseminated his ideas through the monthly Bahishkrit Bharat ('Excluded India').

On 2 March 1930 he led a mass movement seeking entry into the Ram Temple at Nashik. The priests, however, shut the doors, and the participants bathed in the Ram and Lakshman Kunds before returning.

In 1933, however, legislation was passed in Bombay Province permitting the excluded communities to enter temples.

7

In 1927 he met his former teacher Ambedkar. Bhim had lovingly preserved his teacher's letter, and teacher and pupil were overcome with emotion.

Bhim was selected for a committee of the Simon Commission; he recommended universal adult suffrage.

He attended the Round Table Conference in London three times and raised the problems of Dalits.

Then came another blow: the death of his wife Rama.

On 15 April 1948 he married Sharada Kabir, a Brahmin physician.

'Time is running short. The struggle seems fruitless. Hindu—and an untouchable Hindu! No. I shall not fail. Conversion.' The Buddhacharitam given to him by Keluskar would give him strength.

On 14 October 1956, on the day of Dashami, from nine to eleven in the morning at Nagpur, Mahasthavira Chandramani of Gorakhpur would conduct the conversion to Buddhism.

He, his second wife Savita, who was a Brahmin, and hundreds of thousands of others embraced Buddhism.

He placed the dust of the Buddha's feet upon his head and bowed three times.

8

Babasaheb Ambedkar became the Law Minister of independent India. He loved Sanskrit deeply and conversed in it (Aaj, Hindi magazine, issue of 15 September 1949; The Leader, Allahabad, 13 September 1949). At the All India Scheduled Castes Federation he proposed that Sanskrit should become the official language, but younger figures including B. P. Maurya opposed the proposal, and it was withdrawn.

His private library contained hundreds of thousands of books. He donated the entire collection to Siddharth College in Mumbai.

Even after attaining greatness, he did not distance himself from his community or his people.

He attained nirvana on 6 December 1956.

68. Videha · The Parallel Literary Movement

Abstract

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles [Gajendra Thakur's Maithili novel, Volumes 0–1–2; Volume 0, Chapters (−100) to (−1); Volume 1, Chapters 0 to 100; and Volume 2, Chapters 101 to 200]: A Synopsis and Critical Evaluation in the Light of Indian and Western Literary Theory. Three volumes · Chapters −100 to 200 · 301 chapters in all. Part One — Volume 0 (the prehistory): A Literary Review.

Keywords: Videha · Parallel · Movement · Literary Criticism · Maithili

Abstract

This chapter examines ‘Videha · The Parallel Literary Movement’. Gajendra Thakur — A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles [Gajendra Thakur's Maithili kādambarī, Volumes 0–1–2; Volume 0, Chapters (−100) to (−1); Volume 1, Chapters 0 to 100; Volume 2, Chapters 101 to 200]: A Synopsis and Critical Evaluation in the Light of Indian and Western Literary Theory. The story of Garh Narikel, where bodies sink in the pond while names survive upon leaves, flows from the present towards the future in the main novel (Volumes 1 and 2). But Volume 0 travels against the current—back towards its roots.

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles [Gajendra Thakur's Maithili novel, Volumes 0–1–2; Volume 0, Chapters (−100) to (−1); Volume 1, Chapters 0 to 100; and Volume 2, Chapters 101 to 200]: A Synopsis and Critical Evaluation in the Light of Indian and Western Literary Theory.

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles

A Critical Study of the Complete Trilogy

Three volumes · Chapters −100 to 200 · 301 chapters in all

Part One — Volume 0 (the Prehistory): Literary Criticism

Part Two — The Main Novel (Volumes 1–2): Synopsis and Criticism

Appendix — An Anthropological Compendium (All Three Volumes)

Author: Gajendra Thakur

Part One

Volume 0 (the Prehistory) — Literary Criticism

One · A Narrative Returning to Its Roots

The story of the village called Garh Narikel, where bodies sink into the pond but names survive on leaves, flows from present towards future in the main sections (Volumes 1 and 2) of A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles.

Volume 0, however, travels against that current—back towards its roots. This is the prehistory: beginning with Chapter [−100] and proceeding to [−1], its negative numbering discloses twelve hundred years of extended memory upon which the entire narrative edifice of the principal novel stands.

In literature, a 'prequel' frequently becomes a commercial extension of an original work; here it is a philosophical necessity. If the central proposition of the main novel is that 'the crocodile devours the body, not the name', the origin of that proposition, its first articulation, its development, and its testing all take place in Volume 0. The volume is therefore no mere appendix but the epistemological foundation of the original work.

In this review I shall attempt to read Volume 0 from four perspectives: Indian poetics (rasa, dhvani and vakrokti); modern Western theory (memory studies, postcolonial theory and archive theory); the epistemology of Navya-Nyāya; and the Videha framework of parallel history. These four perspectives do not cancel one another; rather, they reveal the text's many layers.

Two · The Architecture of Negative Time

Volume 0's boldest structural decision is its negative chapter numbering. The sequence from [−100] to [−1] continually reminds the reader that the narrative is moving towards 'zero'—the starting point of the main story. This is no mere typographic device; it is a philosophical interpretation of time. The farther a chapter stands from zero, the deeper it lies within history. As the numbers advance towards zero, the reader approaches the present—but is never allowed to forget how deeply that present is indebted to the prolonged past.

> What stood at the beginning stood once more at the end. What had commenced with shell and silver converged again twelve hundred years later, on that night of the new moon.
>
> — Chapter [−3], 'The Circle Completed'

History in this architecture is not linear but circular. The shell–silver illusion of Chapter [−100] and the acknowledgement of the final witness in Chapter [−1] echo one another. The text returns to its origins, bearing in that return the weight of twelve hundred years. This 'circle' is not merely a structure but a theme: names die and are born again; villages sink and rise again; witnesses change, but testimony remains.

Three · Body and Name: The Central Proposition

The intellectual axis of the entire volume lies concealed in a folk saying repeatedly emerging from Garh Narikel's collective memory: 'The crocodile devours the body, not the name.' The novel's whole metaphysics

is contained in this single sentence. The crocodile—that is, time, oblivion, power, violence and the market—swallows bodies; but when the 'name' (memory, record, testimony, identity) survives in speech and on leaves, the person does not perish entirely.

This 'name' is multivalent. It is a person's identity, but it is also a record—a register, an account, written testimony: the ordinary person's only resistance to power. In Chapter [−20] ('The Bridge of Names'), the idea reaches its fullest expression: the stone bridge is swept away by floodwaters, but the bridge made of names—the record of those killed in its construction—stands through the ages. Here the 'name' becomes architecture; remembrance becomes engineering.

> The crocodile eats the body, ah, but not the name. Leave the bridge of stone; build a bridge of names.
>
> — Folk song opening Chapter [−20]

Four · Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti

The Organisation of Rasa

The rasa structure of Volume 0 is plural, yet its predominant rasa is karuṇa, pathos—a compassion that stands against oblivion. Budhua's water burial [−90], the night of the epidemic [−71], and the market in bodies [−35] disclose grief in its dignity, without ever reducing it to mere shrieking. This pathos is accompanied by vīra rasa, heroism, though not the heroism of weapons: it is the courage of memory. Whoever preserves a name, whoever bears witness, is the hero of this novel. The philosophical chapters ('Shell and Silver', the debate over the proof of the self) also explore śānta rasa, tranquillity, in which the intensity of argument finally dissolves into peace.

Dhvani

The work's strength resides in its dhvani, or suggested meaning. The witness tree, the paired ponds, the crocodile, shell and silver—all signify far beyond their literal sense. The 'crocodile' is literally the reptile in the pond, but its suggested meaning brings together time, capital, authority and oblivion. When Chapter [−36] says, 'The old crocodile lived in the water; the new crocodile lives in the wire', the invisible fraud of the internet age is linked through suggestion with the ancient reptile. This continuity of suggestion binds twelve hundred years into a single thread.

Vakrokti

Kuntaka's vakrokti, or obliqueness of expression, is evident here in the arrangement of titles. 'The Bridge of Names', 'Paper in the Throat', 'The Bottom of the Well', 'Tower and Root'—every title is an oblique

metaphor holding contradictions together. Poetic craft resides in this obliqueness: the author bends direct statement towards metaphor, deepening meaning through the turn.

Five · The Epistemology of Navya-Nyāya

The opening octet of Volume 0 (Chapters [−100] to [−93]) is a series of philosophical dramas planting Mithila's Nyāya tradition at the very root of the story. Here Vācaspati Miśra (Bhāmatī), Udayanācārya (Nyāyakusumāñjali) and Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (Tattvacintāmaṇi)—three peaks of Mithila's philosophical tradition—are present both as characters and as echoes.

Chapter [−100], 'Shell and Silver', forms the epistemological gateway to the entire novel. Mistaking a shining shell seen from afar for silver—the classical example of the shell–silver illusion—becomes an argument: whoever knows how to question can escape error. Perception, inference, comparison and verbal testimony, the four pramāṇas, cease to be merely scholastic categories in this drama and become practical instruments of living. The philosophical seed of the whole novel's insistence on 'vigilance'—its imperative to guard against rumour, deception and oblivion—is planted here.

> Illusion lasts but a moment, ah, while truth endures through ages;
> whoever knows to question will not mistake a shell for silver.
>
> — The narrator's folk song in Chapter [−100]

The collection of 'stories, narratives, exempla and quotations' at the end of these philosophical chapters—the water on the highway and the flow of the Ganges, crystal and the hibiscus flower, rope and snake, tat tvam asi and ahaṃ brahmāsmi—is no display of erudition. Voiced by the narrator, among students and village folk, it becomes a living tradition. Scriptural 'quotation' is transformed into popular recitation: the intellectual refinement of Navya-Nyāya descends into the people's voices. This is one of the novel's original contributions: it makes 'philosophy' into 'folk culture'.

Six · Memory, the Archive and Subaltern Voices

From the perspective of modern Western theory, Volume 0 is a rich text. Its central concern—'Who dies, and who is remembered?'—engages directly with memory studies and archive theory. The demand to write down once again the names of those killed in bridge-building, their names struck off the contractor's papers ([−10], [−4], [−30]), imagines a 'counter-archive': the people's record against the official record of power.

The voice of subaltern studies is unmistakable in this volume. 'Light in the Leatherworkers' Quarter' [−91], 'The Owner of the Soil' [−54], 'The Market in Bodies' [−35]—these give voice to those whom history habitually

silences. Yet the novel presents such voices not as the objects of 'rescue' but as 'witnesses': they speak, pronounce their own names and inscribe those names upon leaves. The novel thus offers a poetic response to Gayatri Spivak's question, 'Can the subaltern speak?' The subaltern can speak, provided the village remembers the name.

> The body merges with the earth, ah, but the name remains upon the leaf; whoever is remembered by the village cannot be erased.
>
> — Folk song from Chapter [−96]

From the perspective of trauma theory, the chapters on epidemic, flood, famine and trafficking turn trauma into 'ritual', not a 'cry'. To bind grief into folk song is a popular means of bearing trauma, different from modern clinical language but no less profound.

Seven · The Framework of Parallel History

According to the Videha framework of parallel history, 'history' is not what victors write but what people preserve in their voices. Volume 0 gives that framework narrative form. Twelve hundred years of 'official' history —kings, treaties and wars—remain in the background, while the foreground holds the 'parallel' history: who survived the flood, who preserved the name, who bore witness.

An elegant self-reference occurs in Chapter [−73], which recounts the origins of the tradition of the 'chapter-opening folk song'. Mourning the death of his daughter Radhika, Mohan plays a melody on his flute; in later generations that melody becomes the 'chapter-opening folk song'—the device that introduces every chapter in the main novel (Volume 1). The novel thus gives birth to its own literary device within its fictional world. This is a poignant form of 'metafiction': the form narrates its own origin.

> That same melody travelled onwards and became the opening of the story; at the dawn of every chapter it emerged as a folk song.
>
> — Chapter [−73], 'Mohan's First Melody'

Eight · Folk Song, Narrator and Stagecraft

Volume 0 moves among three narrative voices: the prose of the novel, the dialogue of drama and the verse of folk song. The philosophical chapters assume dramatic form, the historical accounts appear as passages of fiction, and the dawn of each chapter is announced through song. This threefold voicing prevents the narrative from becoming monotonous. The narrator links all three voices: a stage manager, a storyteller and a singer of folk songs at once.

The device of the 'chapter-opening folk song'—each chapter from [−73] to [−1] begins with a named folk melody (a mournful flute tune, a wedding sohar, a vigil song, a courtroom song, a bidesiya song of departure, a

protest song and so on)—weaves Maithili folk music's immense treasury into the architecture of a modern novel. These melodies are no mere ornaments; each establishes the emotional disposition of its chapter in advance. The bidesiya melody embodies the sorrow of migration, the vigil tune the community of an epidemic-stricken night, and the sohar the hope accompanying birth. Folk form and narrative emotion become one.

Nine · Language and Style

The refinement of Maithili prose in this volume is a major achievement. In the philosophical chapters, the language is disciplined and dominated by Sanskrit-derived terminology (pratyakṣa, anumāna, prāmāṇya, abhāva); in the folk songs it is earthy, rhythmic and rich in vernacular forms (the vocatives 'he' and 're', the repeated words 'name', 'crocodile' and 'earth'). This dual register—the scholastic and the popular—also embodies at the linguistic level the novel's fundamental tension between philosophy and folk life, elite culture and common experience.

Particularly striking is the use of proverbs. Each chapter opens with a saying attributed to Garh Narikel, compressing its essence into one line. These sayings are invented, yet their vernacular rhythm is so convincing that they sound like genuinely ancient proverbs. The invention of such original proverbial speech is a rare skill in Maithili narrative writing.

Ten · Evaluation

Volume ০ is an audacious work. Rejecting the commercial ease of the prequel, it fashions itself as a philosophical and historical epic. Its architecture of negative time, its threefold voice, its remarkable conjunction of Navya-Nyāya and folk song, and its central ethical imperative—'preserve the name'—distinguish it in the contemporary Maithili novel.

If it has a limitation, that limitation is its density: the philosophical octet's tight network of argument may initially deter the general reader. Yet for those who pass through that gateway the volume opens an uncommon experience—one in which philosophy becomes narrative, history becomes folk song and memory becomes resistance.

> The lamp may go out, the curtain may fall, ah, yet let the name remain awake; the story of a village that preserves its names can never die.
>
> — The concluding benediction of Chapter [−১], 'The Final Witness'

❖

Part Two

The Main Novel (Volumes 1–2) — Synopsis and Criticism

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles

A Synopsis and Critical Evaluation in the Light of Indian and Western Literary Theory

Author: Gajendra Thakur

1. Introduction

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles is an extraordinary, expansive and multilayered work in the field of the modern Maithili novel. Divided into three volumes—Volume 0 (prehistory: Chapters −100 to −1), Volume 1 (Chapters 0 to 100) and Volume 2 (Chapters 101 to 200)—its 301 chapters refuse confinement within conventional plotting. Instead, the text interweaves folk epic, archival narrative, social realism, philosophical novel, mystery investigation, folk theatre, memoir and communal documentation of resistance. At the centre stands the village of Garh Narikel, yet it is far more than a geographical location: it is a world in which memory, soil, labour, water, caste, women's experience, folk belief, technological modernity and institutional injustice collide.

This criticism focuses primarily on the main novel—Volumes 1 and 2 (Chapters 0 to 200). A detailed literary analysis of Volume 0 (the prehistory, Chapters −100 to −1) is provided separately in Part One of this study. Together the three volumes constitute a single, unbroken journey through twelve hundred years of testimony.

The novel's basic ethical question is simple but profoundly serious: after a human body dies, what becomes of the person's name, labour, rights and memory? When the state, the market, the courts, universities, charities, banks, digital platforms, telephones, archives and caste-bound society reduce a human being to a number, a form, an account, a percentage, an image or the word ‘absent’, what remains literature's responsibility? The novel seeks an answer not in the victory of an individual hero, but in communal remembrance, the reading aloud of names, consent, testimony, folk song, children's games and unceasing vigilance.

The work is important because it does not simply depict injustice; it constructs a method of knowledge necessary for securing justice. Perception, inference, testimony, non-apprehension, memory, remnants, voices, bodies, footprints, seals, torn papers, discarded sacks, empty trunks, dried leaves, the smell of earth and the movement of water all become evidence. In this sense the novel is not just a story, but an alternative discipline of knowledge and ethical accountability.

This work calls itself a ‘Maithili kādambarī’ and contains three appendices: the Garh Narikel Folk Encyclopaedia, the original songs of the Nameless Planet episode, and the original philosophical inner narrative of Nyāya. These appendices are not decorative; they explicitly lay before us the work's foundations in folk culture, dream and śāstra.

2. The Work in One Sentence

Through the joint efforts of children, women, workers, the dead, repentant witnesses and communal memory, the names of those submerged in Garh Narikel's river, bridge, courts, platforms, markets, charities and archives are raised to the surface again, until the village itself becomes a ‘guardian of names’.

3. Detailed Synopsis

3.1 Establishing the Folk World

Chapter Zero introduces Garh Narikel's folk culture. Soil, water, fields, ponds, trees, floods, work songs, wedding songs, women's voices, children's games, folk deities, nirgun devotional song, marsiya lament, craftsmanship, occupational knowledge and caste inequality together create the novel's geography. This introduction establishes that the narrative to follow unfolds not in an empty modern space, but within a living landscape of cultural remembrance. In Garh Narikel, knowledge does not reside only in books and offices; it inhabits hands, ears, feet, songs, sayings and collective experience.

Channa Gachhi is the central site of memory in this world. At night, ghosts, spirits, demons, loth, water-drowned spirits and other souls of the prematurely dead play kabaddi there. The game is not entertainment but the dead's folk tribunal. Its fundamental rule—cross the boundary, preserve your breath, return with a name—becomes the formal principle of the whole novel. Whoever can return bearing a name remains present in history; whoever forgets a name loses the turn.

Chapter Zero assembles twenty-four folk episodes—from leaf-lamps on Dakahi Pond, the songs of rice transplantation, the samdaun of a daughter's departure, mourning songs, the silent song of aripan designs, the lamps of jhijhiya, Kabir's nirgun voice, and songs of court dates and popular justice, all the way to warnings against digital fraud. It announces that the first and final protagonist of this kādambarī is the people themselves—their songs, their memory and their consciousness of justice.

3.2 The Bridge Disaster, Drowned Workers and the First Struggle over Names

The narrative opens with urgency through bridge construction, a river accident and scenes of innumerable labourers' deaths. The official register contains thirty names, but the actual deaths are suggested to number around three hundred. Bisesar Paswan, Saryu, Kanhaiya, Shivnath Sada and many unnamed workers, whose labour lies buried within the bridge, remain absent, incomplete or distorted on paper. Bodies sink in the river, but names sink within the system.

Nand Aruni becomes the first alert witness to this discrepancy. He reads a torn gamchha, shoes, a tiffin box, an incomplete slip, a diary and the sound of a splash as evidence. Here 'splash' is not simply the sound of a body falling into water, but the sound of a system making human beings disappear. Nand's petitions, lists of the dead and diary take the story into courts, offices and a distant financial world.

3.3 The Crocodile's Expanding Forms

Across the opening chapters of Volume 1, the 'crocodile' gradually assumes multiple institutional forms. In court it is the 'crocodile of adjournments', devouring the litigant's years. During the epidemic, it transforms life into a market commodity through the 'price of breath'. On digital platforms and telephones it enters as online gambling, debt, deception, blackmail and invasion of privacy. 'The Market in Bodies' turns women's bodies, images, consent and dignity into commodities. 'The Dark River of Money' is the secret flow of illicit accounts, mule accounts, overseas channels, donations and financial crime.

Harvard's lectures on ethics, Edward Broom's civilised phrases, Chandrapal Batra's financial platform, Raghav 'Signal' and his disappearing messages, Lau Kin-Hung's nameless accounts, and Batuknath Hariharan's legal ingenuity together demonstrate that modern exploitation is not merely local thuggery: it is a coalition of expertise, prestige, technology, law, capital and the global language of ethics.

3.4 The Court of Channa Gachhi and a New Politics of the Defeated

Human courts give delays, red tape and decrees of victory; the court of Channa Gachhi demands memory, names and self-acknowledgement. Here the dead are not judges but moral mirrors. Even those who prevail in external courts are defeated before their inner tribunal. Their punishment is neither imprisonment nor execution, but reading and pronouncing the names associated with their actions, carrying those names home and bearing their weight.

One of the novel's most original features is that the 'defeated' do not raise slogans of revenge but set about their own work. Devika provides education against digital fraud; Meera establishes a forum for privacy, consent and the right to one's image; Ira reads names on an international ethical stage; Gop Kumar safeguards records; children establish a school of names. The meaning of victory therefore changes. True victory lies not in defeating an adversary, but in building a society where the next victim is not left alone.

3.5 The School of Names and Inheritance between Generations

Ananya and Aruni represent the next generation. They read the names of the dead aloud, answering 'Present'. Reading names is not simply reciting a list; it restores families, labour, unrealised dreams, bodies and rights. Chapters such as 'The School against the Screen', 'The Oath of Privacy', 'Three Pebbles', 'Pronouncing the Name', 'The Boat of Names', 'The Granddaughter's Notebook' and 'The Next Voice' turn the safeguarding of memory into an educational practice.

Three pebbles—home, fear and dream—become a principle of ethical education for children. They ask of each name: Where was that person's home? What was their fear? What was their dream? These questions restore the dead as whole human beings rather than data. Education here is not the fixed text of a book, but an exercise in hearing living testimony in the community.

3.6 Felling, the Commodification of Memory and a New Struggle

After Channa Gachhi is felled, the stump remains. It is wounded memory —destroyed, yet not lifeless. Municipal notices, heritage projects, tenders involving remembrance, memorial apps, Harvard research teams, processions of counterfeit ghosts and deeds of donation all seek to make memory into marketable property once more. Questions arise about ownership of the dead's stories, images, dramatisation, research and tourism. Meera defends the 'right to one's image', while Devika opposes the use of memory without permission.

Here the novel raises distinctly contemporary questions: Who may tell the victim's story? Who may retain their image? If the dead cannot consent, what roles should be played by family, community and dignity? Is a memorial an act of justice or a market in memory? The answers are not one-dimensional; the narrative consistently stresses consent, participatory decisions and respect for spaces left empty.

3.7 The Women's Assembly, Workers' Feet and a Constitution of Names

The women's night assembly constitutes one of the novel's ethical centres. After the male-dominated language of public life, women's voices reveal the material body of experience. Moisture in a shirt, cracked heels, a red thread, waiting for a son, wounds to privacy, domestic silence and caste humiliation become more authoritative than official testimony.

'The Workers' Feet' reads the history of labour not from the architecture of the bridge, but from bodily fatigue, cracked heels and sweat. 'Fasting from the Screen' redirects sight and hearing towards human faces. 'Satyavrat's Public Hearing' and 'The Constitution of Names' establish a communal ethical code: do not erase names, do not sell privacy, do not dishonour the body, do not put memory out to contract, and ask after the names of the absent.

3.8 Flood, the Crocodiles' Return and Partial Confession

Another flood returns the story to the elemental crisis of water. The crocodiles' return makes clear that a single victory is not a permanent solution. Greed can always return in new papers, proposals, institutions and technological forms. Lau Kin-Hung recognises the childhood wound of his namelessness; Batuknath offers a belated apology; Chandrapal realises that his entire life has become a mule account; Raghav's deleted messages finally become indelible testimony; Satyavrat acknowledges his silence.

The novel clearly distinguishes the causes of wrongdoing from its forgiveness. Childhood humiliation, fear and social injury may make crime comprehensible, but not innocent. Confession is necessary, yet cannot substitute for justice, restitution and public accountability.

3.9 The Elephant-and-Crocodile Parable and the Nameless Planet

Volume 1 ends with 'The Elephant, the Crocodile and the Child's Hand'. The novel gives the Purāṇic episode of the elephant and crocodile a new meaning. The conflict between the powerful elephant and the crocodile clutching it is resolved not by miraculous deliverance from above, but by a child's hand, the hearing of a name and communal cooperation.

At the beginning of Volume 2, Aruni and the children dream of a nameless planet. It is without suffering because memory has been erased; houses bear numbers instead of names. This apparent utopia is in truth a totalitarian regime of oblivion. Under the pretence of abolishing suffering, history, crime and relationships have been obliterated. The children play kabaddi among the inhabitants and bring names back. Ultimately Garh Narikel chooses the wounded Earth. This is not a choice

of despair but an acceptance of responsibility: fleeing an imperfect Earth for a heaven without memory would be a moral evasion.

3.10 Keeping Watch over the Earth: From Seed to Justice

From Chapters 105 to 132, the narrative establishes a vigil over the Earth's elements and the social body. Seed bears witness to the future; stealing seed is stealing tomorrow's food. Soil raises questions of ownership, caste, acquisition, chemicals and debt. Water remembers; fire turns the ashes of burned documents into testimony; air is a collective right; the emptiness of the sky is not an invitation to escape, but a question of responsibility.

The Body of Words, the Soul of Meaning, the Vigil of the Voice, the Inheritance of Silence, the Debt of Memory, the Right to the Body, the Body of Labour and the Body of Justice—this sequence brings social justice down from abstract concepts into embodied practice. 'The Cage of Caste' reveals caste's subtle presence in tradition, food, marriage, touch, cremation grounds and kitchens. 'The Liberation of Gaṅgeśa' makes Mithila's great philosopher not merely a revered symbol but an embodiment of the right to ask questions. 'A Leaf of the Tattvacintāmaṇi' turns the epistemology of perception, inference, testimony and non-apprehension into an instrument of popular justice.

The chapters on grain, hunger, thirst, salt, taste, the shared plate and the republic of the kitchen clarify that justice is not confined to judicial decisions: it takes visible shape in fields, boundaries, water, hearths, food, shared seating and caste-free kitchens. Eating from one plate challenges the hidden structures of power within society.

3.11 A Novel inside a Play, a Public Hearing inside a Novel

In the episode of the Videha Theatre Festival, the novel transforms its first 132 chapters into a dramatic reading. The story rises onto the stage but does not surrender its substance by turning into a synopsis. The silence after the applause, spectators' testimonies, the procession outside the theatre, street performance and the travelling village forum carry art beyond presentation into social accountability.

The spectator is no longer a passive consumer but becomes a witness. The hand applauds, signs documents, commits crimes and also testifies. When theatre enters the street, the stage's hierarchy collapses. Performance rooted in folk life becomes collective writing and a travelling court.

3.12 Archival Investigation: From the Veranda to the City's Accounts

From Chapter 141 onward, the story assumes the form of an extended archival investigation. The veranda is an intermediate state of waiting; the records room is the darkness of obstructed time; the sack of waste paper

bears witness to discarded lives. The name in a file returns to the doorstep. Fear begins to crack. The stain left by a seal appears darker on a hand than on paper. A knock at each door is made not by command but by permission.

The adulterated identity, the map of the network, the seal's shadow, the source of the order, the name behind the signal, the father's promise, the account of service, the debt of a donation, the iron trunk, the matching of consent notebooks, the consent of the dead and the warehouse's shadow—these chapters examine minutely how institutions, charity, faith, hunger, medicine and relief can become instruments for stealing consent. A thumbprint obtained on a night of illness or a day of starvation is not freely given. Consent manufactured after death is the cheapest piece of paper and the costliest crime.

3.13 Telephones, Voices and the Industry of Fear

Imprisonment by Phone, the Seal of the Voice, Traces of Removed Papers, the Stomach of Chandrapal's Shadow, the Warehouse at Imli Ghat, the Voice across the River, the City's Throat, and the Shells of Chandra Two and Chandra One—this sequence links the digital fraud network to social trust, pensions, lawsuits, sons abroad, women's names, the fears of old people and institutional voices. Criminals do not merely deploy technological tricks; they imitate family speech, the mother's voice, the cadence of official instructions, a fan's sound, station schedules and local patterns of trust.

Channa Gachhi's 'invisible court' becomes a safe place for victims to untie their fear. Knots are read slowly; they are not ripped open by force. The vigil over registers, doorsteps, seal-bearers, service ceremonies, door-to-door papers, the upstairs room, the seal's footprints and city accounts connect the local and urban strands of the crime.

3.14 The Final Layer of Crime and the Resurrection of Names

The Shadow of the SIM, the Door of the Service Centre, the Face inside the Phone, the Mask of the Voice, the Master's Room, Madhavesh's Real Name, the Queen within the Hive, Maheshwar's Seal, the Iron Box, the Blue Register, Dhruvesh's Chair, the Voice of the Silent Recorder, the Face of the Voice, the Summons of Breath and the Frozen Account—these chapters disclose the crime's multilayered organisation. Madhukar Madhav Mishra, Maheshwarnath Sevak, Dhruvesh and their associated organisations conduct business in names, women's accounts, voices, seals, aid lists and fear.

Freezing accounts is an act of justice, but the novel warns that the poor person's pension, a student's assistance or a legitimate household fire must

not thereby be extinguished. The rigour of truth and compassionate discernment are both necessary. The chapter 'The Meaning of Water Burial' unfolds the title's central insight: water is not the criminal; the true force of submergence is a system that seizes the name after the body has gone. The silence of those standing on the bank deepens the burial.

'The Names Raised to the Surface' resists spectacle. The victim's permission, respect for the family's silence and the right to wait are indispensable. 'The Criminal's Earth' teaches the ethical discipline of preserving evidence. 'Morning inside the Trunk' brings Shivnath Sada's name out of false absence and back to his threshold. In the final chapter, 'Guardians of Names', the village reads again the titles of all 301 chapters. The dead hand over the staff of judgement to the living. The children form a circle again: whoever crosses the line must return with a name. The story pauses, but does not end, because justice is not a single decision but a continuous vigil.

4. Principal Characters and Communal Heroism

This is not the story of one hero in the conventional sense. Its true protagonist is 'the awakened community of Garh Narikel'. Even so, certain characters perform distinctive ethical and structural roles.

Nand Aruni is the first witness, archivist and ethical initiator. His diary, petitions and reckoning of splashes take the narrative from private grief to public evidence. His importance lies in the fact that he does not glorify impossible truths: he pieces together small objects, incomplete names and missing lines.

Aruni embodies the alert consciousness of the next generation, forming a bridge among technology, registers, dreams and folk memory. Ananya is the most compelling embodiment of children's moral intelligence. Her questions test complex institutional language against straightforward human standards. She is not a fearless warrior heroine; she accepts responsibility despite being afraid, and that makes her credible.

Meera represents the ethics of sight, the body, images, privacy and consent. Her role is crucial to the critique of contemporary visual culture. She rejects the assumption that victims' images, memories of the dead or women's bodies may be treated as freely available objects in the name of public interest.

Devika embodies resistance through education. She turns Ujjwal's death from a private shame into a social warning. Ira brings local names into the hollowness of international ethical platforms. Satyavrat Mehta represents conscience within the legal establishment—awakened late, burdened by the fault of silence, yet prepared for confession and public testimony.

Ba, Phoolkali, Surmani, Jagmaya, Shanti, Dhirmati and the other women of the assembly preserve folk memory, grief, consent, food, the body and ethical fortitude. The ghosts, spirits, water-drowned souls and the old ghost are more than the dead: they are metaphors of collective memory.

Chandrapal, Batuknath, Raghav, Lau, Broom, Madhukar, Maheshwar, Dhruvesh and the other antagonists are not uniformly demonic. They represent different coalitions of capital, law, technology, charity, prestige, namelessness, fear and the rhetoric of service. Some receive psychological histories, but the novel does not turn their wounds into absolution for their crimes.

5. The Characters' Accounts after the Entire Journey

After this long journey through three volumes and 301 chapters, if we sit beside the stump at Channa Gachhi and take account of who gained what, who lost what, and who disappeared where, the following reckoning emerges.

1. Those Whose Names Were Recovered after Death

Bisesar Paswan — He died at the bridge foundation and was marked 'absent' in the register. By the journey's end, however, his shoes, his name and his labour have become immortal in the village's enduring memory, on a clay tablet and in the testimony of an iron box. Nothing was gained that could restore him to life, yet his name was recovered—the novel's greatest 'victory'.

Saryu — A woman worker whose name officially did not exist because she worked under her husband's name. In the end, Satyavrat Mehta reads her name aloud in the courtroom. Her thumbprint, once invisible to the law, becomes the first lesson of justice.

Chhotu (Bholatun) — The underage son of a Musahar woman, whose real name was recovered from the village's collective memory. Muniya, Dhanesari, Nagina and many others: all their names are preserved in the final chapter's 'Roll of Silence' and on the clay tablets. Empty places are left for those whose names are nowhere to be found. As Ba says, an empty place also bears witness.

Ujjwal Jha — Victim of a digital-arrest scam, he took his own life. Although he lost his life, his death became the seed of the exposure of the whole network (Chandrapal Batra, Raghav Signal and Lau Kin-Hung). Through the struggle of his sister Devika Sah, his name became a symbol of the village's movement for justice: personal loss was transformed into collective awakening.

2. Living Characters Whose Journeys Reached Completion

Nand Aruni and His Lineage

Nand Aruni — The principal witness in Volume 1, he lost his engineering career through transfers and exclusion. But he left behind the principle 'One copy with Mother, one beside the water, one with the wind', which became the foundation of testimony preservation throughout the novel. Ba — The maternal voice, she remained alive to the end and saw three or four generations of her family walking the path of justice—her greatest gain. Aruni (Nand's descendant) — He witnessed the final courtroom victory through the reading of names and took up leadership of the village. Ananya — A central pupil of the school from childhood, she ultimately became keeper of the register, the village's permanent archivist; hers was the greatest responsibility.

Leaders of the New Generation

Ira Aruni — Born abroad, she challenged Edward Broom at Harvard and came to understand her family name as evidence rather than a burden. She lost faith in the hypocrisy of international institutions but rediscovered her roots. Meera (Mrinalini Arya) — A victim of invasion of privacy and blackmail, she nevertheless did not lose her love for Aditi or her dignity; she found the courage to speak as a witness rather than a victim. Devika Sah — She lost her brother Ujjwal forever, an irreparable loss, but through that grief emerged as the village's boldest voice. Phoolmati — Freed from a human-trafficking network, she publicly regained her real name and the right to say, 'My name is Phoolmati, not FM'.

Investigators and Advocates of Justice

Gop Kumar — He lost his corporate career through reduced privileges and exclusion from the folder, but gained credit for exposing the entire network and a measure of moral fulfilment. He devised the three-copy system. Soumya Ramanathan and Ramaiyya Subramanyam — Constant allies who earned trustworthiness and the confidence of the village. Satyavrat Mehta — He sacrificed the comfortable career of a government lawyer and old friendships, but entered history as a man who stood for truth against the state. Reading the names of the dead aloud in court became the defining testimony of his life.

3. Criminal Characters: Downfall and Partial Atonement

Batuknath Hariharan — He lost the lustre, status and moral authority associated with the Bar Council. His son's question ('Did you save justice or your profession?') shook him from within. In the end he apologised, too

late to restore the wasted years. His accounts were frozen and his name entered in the register of offenders.

Chandrapal Batra — His mule-account network was completely exposed and his bank accounts frozen. The childhood wound of having his name distorted by a teacher was revealed as an unacknowledged root of his wrongdoing. He had been forced to live with half a name, only to be caught at last under his full name.

Raghav Somani ('Signal') — He had unwittingly deleted the last recording of his mother's voice, a loss that broke him inwardly. He wrote his last and most candid message, but his entire network—his game of 'networks without trust'—came to an end.

Lau Kin-Hung — A Hong Kong intermediary, he decided his final bargain through his memory of a childhood refugee identity, when he had been called by an incorrect number. His accounts were frozen, but he remained the most distant and elusive. The novel grants him no scene of personal atonement, only institutional defeat.

Edward Broom — The international face of the networks involving the bridge, medicines and gambling, he never receives direct punishment. Ira's questions and the village's rejection of his donation document strip away his ethical mask. Yet the novel clearly suggests that powerful international offenders of this kind frequently escape full punishment: 'Some criminals will flee; some will be caught' (Chapter 200).

Malvika Green, Madhavesh, Maheshwar and Dhruvesh — Intermediate operators who are exposed one after another, but whose individual endings the novel does not make explicit. The uncertainty is itself a comment on systemic crime: the names and ultimate fates of all the guilty can never be completely known.

4. Missing and Mysterious Characters

Ishan Dutt — The most mysterious character, one who never cast a shadow and had already been declared 'dead' in government records. Throughout the novel he offers information and courage, yet reaches no personal resolution at the end. He simply departs, saying, 'If one person dies, another will speak.' He remains not an individual but a collective symbol of unnamed informants. His 'disappearance' is itself his greatest truth: those who erase their identities to protect truth can never fully be encountered as individuals.

Shashibhushan Dev, Mahendra Pathak, Victor Halden and Divakar Lal — Corrupt officials from the beginning of Volume 1 who vanish from the narrative after Nand Aruni's transfer. Their accounts are never fully settled, a realistic depiction of impunity in lower-level corruption.

The Old Ghost, Hulasi, the water-drowned spirits, loth, demons, witches and the Brahma spirit of the peepal tree — These supernatural judges of Garh Narikel have administered justice to the dead for twelve hundred years. In the final chapter they voluntarily place their staff of judgement in the hands of the living: 'Let the living decide now.' They have never been defeated, yet surrender their central role and become watchkeepers only. This voluntary, dignified 'defeat' is, in truth, complete victory.

Conclusion

At the end of the entire journey, we realise that no single hero has won and no villain has been wholly defeated. What has won is the name, which rises again and again after death, forgetting and crime. What is lost irretrievably is life itself: the lives of Ujjwal, Saryu, Bisesar and countless unnamed labourers will never return. Yet names remain, along with the responsibility Ananya and the village children have taken upon their shoulders. In this sense the story is never fully 'over': so long as even one mouth says, 'I am here', the vigil continues.

6. The Title's Multiple Meanings

6.1 What 'Crocodile' Means

In the novel the crocodile moves beyond the boundaries of a natural creature to become a structural antagonist. The river crocodile is visible terror, but the actual crocodiles are concealed in court dates, digital platforms, banks, markets, universities, caste, charity, records, reputation, invasions of privacy, silence and the appetite for profit. The crocodile's defining features—teeth, grip, ambush, concealment under water and dragging prey below—become metaphors for institutional violence.

Crucially, the novel does not make any single person the centre of all evil. Each individual is a knot in the network; the crocodile's entire body is constituted by institutions, habits, conveniences and collective silence. In this sense the plural 'crocodiles' is profoundly significant.

6.2 What 'Water Burial' Means

Water burial is meaningful on at least five levels. First, it is the actual drowning of bodies in the river. Second, it is the submergence of names in registers. Third, it is the disappearance of personhood into debt, platforms, the body trade, telephones and accounts. Fourth, it is the forgetting of suffering within society's silence. Fifth, it is rebirth within memory: when names rise above the water, death is no longer the final word.

Thus, although the title is filled with pathos, it is not pessimistic. Water burial signifies destruction, yet water itself is also a medium of memory, testimony and renewal. The river may carry bodies away, but not names.

7. Principal Symbols and the Imagery System

Channa Gachhi is at once a people's parliament, an archive of memory, a court, a school and a stage. Its felling is an assault on history; its stump is wounded continuity; a small green point upon it signals rebirth.

A coconut leaf is an alternative page. Paper can fall subject to lies, cancellation and seals; the leaf is associated with the community, the seasons and nature's memory. Even a dry leaf preserves stories within its veins.

A splash is a sonic symbol. Initially the sound of death, it later becomes the sound of a platform breaking, a paper opening, memory awakening and an answer being given.

The name is the minimal yet supreme right of existence. It brings together person, family, labour, body, inheritance, justice and remembrance. In the novel a name is not merely a linguistic sign, but an ethical relationship.

Kabaddi is a metaphor of breath, boundaries, risk, return and communal rules. Crossing the line is courage; returning with a name is responsibility; preserving one's breath is memory; the voices of teammates are community.

The blank plaque, empty trunk, removed page, marks in dust and vacant chair are active symbols of absence. What is not there becomes present as a question.

Seals, accounts, registers, trunks, recorders and telephones are symbols of institutional embodiment. Such objects are not neutral; they bear impressions of human hands, fear, profit and history.

8. An Evaluation in the Light of Indian Literary Theory

8.1 Rasa Theory

The work's enduring emotional ground is compassion. Drowned labourers, waiting mothers, cracked heels, empty plates, erased names, the body trade, consent attributed to the dead and justice delayed for years evoke karuṇa rasa. This compassion, however, is not passive. Within it, raudra, vīra and śānta rasas develop and transform in sequence.

Raudra rasa manifests in the community's anger against injustice, but the novel does not let that anger turn into violent revenge. Vīra rasa resides in writing names, testifying, seeking consent, safeguarding records, breaking the cage of caste and untying the knots of fear. Adbhuta rasa arises from the ghosts' kabaddi, letters upon leaves, water's memory and dreams of the nameless planet. Bhayānaka rasa inhabits crocodiles, dark record rooms, counterfeit voices and water-drowned spirits. Bībhatsa rasa appears in the

trade in bodies, manufactured consent of the dead, forged thumbprints and the conversion of human suffering into profit.

The final śānta rasa is not detached stillness, but alert ethical equanimity. The dead lay down the staff of judgement and the living assume the vigil. In Abhinavagupta's sense, the universalisation of pathos lifts the spectator above private grief towards an experience common to humanity. Yet this novel does not establish universality by erasing particular names: its universalisation preserves the specificity of names.

8.2 Dhvani Theory

In the light of Ānandavardhana's theory of dhvani, the work is exceptionally rich. The literal meanings of 'crocodile', 'water burial', 'splash', 'name', 'stump', 'leaf', 'breath', 'seal' and 'vacancy' are limited, but their suggested meanings are immense. The 'crocodile of adjournments' suggests that a court date is not merely a day but a mechanism that devours justice. The 'crocodile of the screen' transforms a digital medium into a psychological hunting ground.

Rasa-dhvani is particularly effective where a scene discloses its own significance: a blank plaque, a green point on the stump, a dead person's signature, children playing kabaddi while reciting names, Dhruvesh's shoes, dew on leaves. After such scenes, meanings reverberate within the reader.

8.3 Vakrokti Theory

According to Kuntaka's theory of vakrokti, poetic quality inheres in the distinctive obliqueness of an ordinary utterance. The novel animates institutional objects: a court becomes a pond, red tape becomes the hair of a water spirit, a cupboard becomes a dark chamber, dust a clerk, a seal a wound, an account a river, a register a watchman and a screen a crocodile. This obliqueness is not ornamentation alone; it is a method for making the structures of power visible.

The work is powerful at both the levels of verbal obliqueness and episodic obliqueness. 'The Novel Begins Again', 'The Story Has Not Ended', a novel inside a play, and the rereading of all chapters at the end are examples of structural or prabandha-vakratā.

8.4 The Principle of Aucitya

From Kṣemendra's perspective of aucitya, or propriety, the folk songs, kabaddi, ghost stories, river, leaves, women's assembly, shared plate and folk theatre emerge organically from the narrative world. Their conjunction of Mithila's folk life and contemporary institutional crises is largely apt and meaningful.

Nevertheless, the criterion of propriety also reveals certain limitations. The recurrence of maxims, songs, philosophical undertones and final ethical statements in every chapter at times makes the meaning too explicit. Where a symbol already speaks for itself, further explanation diminishes the space available for suggestion. Thus the work's conceptual propriety is strong, though a degree of artistic restraint seems necessary in places.

8.5 Rīti, Guṇa and Language

From the standpoint of Vāmana's rīti theory, the novel's predominant qualities are prasāda (clarity) and ojas (vigour). Its language clarifies meaning through accessible images, folk sayings and rhythmic aphorisms; vigour is particularly strong in scenes of injustice. The women's assembly, mourning songs, leaves, dew and salt also display mādhurya, sweetness.

The work's distinctive rīti may be called a ‘folk-archival style’: vernacular speech, administrative vocabulary, technical terms, songs, philosophical concepts and legal formulations penetrate one another within the same idiom.

8.6 Sādhāraṇīkaraṇa and Lokamaṅgala

According to Bhaṭṭa Nāyaka's conception of universalisation, private emotion becomes a shared experience through art. The novel transforms the suffering of specific characters—Bisesar, Saryu, Shivnath, Ujjwal, Phoolkali and others—into an experience embracing all those who have been forgotten. Yet this universality is not achieved by converting them into an abstract ‘poor’ or ‘victim’, but by preserving their particular names, castes, occupations, bodies and places.

From the perspective of lokamaṅgala, or the common good, in modern Indian criticism, the work treats literature as a means for society's ethical reconstruction. The school, shared plate, public hearing, theatre, constitution, vigilance over memory and preservation of records are active forms of the common good.

8.7 Lokadharmī and Nāṭyadharmī

Within Bharata Muni's tradition, lokadharmī performance is close to the natural conduct of life, while nāṭyadharmī is a stylised presentation. The novel combines the two. The ghosts' kabaddi at Channa Gachhi is stylised, metaphorical and nāṭyadharmī; workers' feet, women's heels, court verandas, discarded paper sacks and pension lists belong to lokadharmī realism. The Videha Theatre Festival consciously stages this duality.

9. Navya-Nyāya and the Novel's Epistemology

The work's most original intellectual achievement is its connection of Navya-Nyāya thought about pramāṇas with social justice. Perception is not restricted to what the eyes see: bodies, footsteps, smell, sounds, sweat, soil and the feel of paper extend its domain. Inference leads from dust, marks left by removed pages, tyres, breath heard in voices, the pressure of seals and the flow of accounts to an otherwise invisible criminal network. Verbal testimony appears in the victims' accounts, folk songs, women's voices and children's questions. Non-apprehension—what has not been found—is central evidence: a missing name on a list, an expected document absent from a trunk, a vacant chair, a removed page, a switched-off recorder, or consent that cannot possibly have been given.

This epistemology is profoundly democratic. Truth does not belong exclusively to experts, judges or universities. Dust, an elderly litigant, women's memories, children's questions, artisans' eyes and village speech help to establish evidence. Nevertheless, the novel does not endorse uncritical folk belief; it recognises the need to detect tampering, investigate, preserve sequence and copies, seek permission, and examine counter-evidence. A balance between popular knowledge and reason is thereby maintained.

10. Evaluation in the Light of Western Literary Theory

10.1 Aristotle's Mimesis, Plot and Catharsis

From Aristotle's perspective, the novel imitates life, yet it does not accept the conventional structure of a single linear action, one protagonist and one climax. Its plot is circular, episodic and wave-like. Each crisis returns in a new form. Causal relations are nevertheless present: the bridge disaster leads to the search for names; the search for names to courts; courts to the school; the school to the constitution; the constitution to archival investigation; and investigation to the exposure of financial and technological networks.

Aristotelian catharsis here is more than an emotional purgation through fear and compassion. The reader does not grieve and thereby become free of responsibility; instead, the reader assumes the ethical duty of becoming a watchkeeper. The work transforms catharsis into civic responsibility.

10.2 Lukács and Social Totality

Georg Lukács's realist conception of totality clarifies the novel's significance. The bridge disaster is not an isolated event; it is linked to the labour market, contracting, courts, banks, universities, epidemics, digital platforms, the body trade, philanthropy, caste, land, seed, food and global

capital. The local village becomes a social totality connected with the world system.

The characters frequently take on the contours of social types: the lawyer, financial broker, technical operator, charitable guru, silent official, awakened child, and woman guarding memory. Typification clarifies the social structure, though psychological subtlety sometimes diminishes as a result. Herein lie both the work's Lukácsian accomplishment and its limitation.

10.3 Marxist Criticism

From a Marxist perspective, the novel offers a sharp account of the unequal relationship between labour and capital. The bridge is built with workers' bodies, while its benefits go to contractors, financial institutions and people of prestige. Workers' names are erased because a name demands accountability; numbers are more convenient for exploitation.

Commodity fetishism and reification pervade the novel at multiple levels: the price of breath, the market in bodies, the sale of privacy, the tendering of memory, seed patents, water privatisation, indebtedness through charity, the imitation of voices and accounts opened under women's names. Human labour and relationships become commodities; commodities—seals, accounts and platforms—acquire human power.

Donation and service become gentler forms of domination. A thumbprint secured in exchange for assistance is turned into future silence. This accords with Gramsci's conception of hegemony and consent: power endures not only through force but through trust, faith, favours, prestige and common sense.

10.4 Bakhtin's Polyphony and Dialogism

From Mikhail Bakhtin's perspective on polyphony, the work is exceptionally fertile. Folk song, the voices of ghosts, children's questions, legal language, technical messages, women's speech, philosophical undertones, administrative documents, maxims, letters, drama and silence all appear as distinct social languages.

The kabaddi game at Channa Gachhi is a carnivalesque inversion. The dead examine the living, children question officials, waste paper discloses the truth of the archive, and an empty chair rules over power. Hierarchies are overturned.

Nevertheless, complete polyphony is sometimes restricted by the author's strongly pronounced ethical voice. Explicit conclusions at the ends of chapters, philosophical undertones and recurrent maxims prevent different

voices from following their independent paths to the end. The characters speak in many voices, but the ethical direction is usually predetermined.

10.5 Foucault: Power, Archives and Biopolitics

From Michel Foucault's perspective, the novel exposes the subtle mechanisms of modern power. Power is not confined to the police or courts: registers, hospitals, pensions, universities, identity cards, mobile phones, banks, cameras, aid lists and research institutions classify, measure and regulate bodies and populations.

'Thirty names, three hundred corpses' expresses the cruelty of biopolitical counting. Who is considered alive, who dead, whose death is legally recognised and whose grief can be publicly acknowledged—power makes these decisions. Data about privacy, voice and the body become instruments of modern discipline.

The records room, register, seal, consent notebook and blue list embody archival power. But the novel also constructs a counter-archive: leaves, songs, children's exercise books, women's memories, objects, dust and copies preserved by the community.

10.6 Derrida: Signs, Absence and the Archive

Through Jacques Derrida's deconstructive perspective, the novel continually unsettles binaries such as present/absent, alive/dead, paper/leaf, original/copy and centre/margin. The absent individual becomes all the more powerfully present in names, shoes, sounds and blank spaces. A removed page leaves its outline in dust. An empty trunk raises more questions than a full one.

A 'trace' is what remains after a crime. Meaning is not locked within one definitive document; it spreads across leaves, water, memory, bodies, voices and rereading. At the end, the rereading of chapter titles recirculates the archive: the text becomes a copy of its own history.

10.7 Memory and Trauma Theory

In the light of theories of collective memory, Garh Narikel is a community of remembrance. According to Maurice Halbwachs, memory is formed within social frameworks; the novel gives this insight concrete expression through folk songs, thresholds, trees, leaves, rivers, games and the annual reading of names.

Trauma is not simply an event that occurs once: it returns in the form of the 'splash', the platform, court dates, floods, voices and blank pages. Repetition begins as compulsive remembrance and later becomes

conscious 'working through'. Testimony, the reading of names, theatre, the constitution and archival protection give trauma public meaning.

The work opposes turning mourning into spectacle. It regards the victim's consent, the right to silence and the need to wait as essential. This accords with the ethical principles of trauma literature.

10.8 Feminist Criticism

From a feminist standpoint, the novel makes a serious intervention in the politics of bodies, looking, consent, privacy, shame, domestic silence, labour and food. Meera raises the question of visual rights: who may view an image, publish it or profit from it? The women's night assembly gives voice to domestic labour and suffering invisible in public history.

'Consent of the Dead', 'An Account in a Woman's Name', 'The Queen within the Hive', 'The Shared Plate' and 'The Republic of the Kitchen' criticise the appropriation of women's names and labour by family and institution. Shame is shifted from the victim's head to the offender's.

Yet a number of women characters perform symbolic ethical roles; the plurality of their private wishes, desires, contradictions and individual struggles could have been developed further. The community of women is powerful, but particular women's psychology sometimes dissolves into a collective metaphor.

10.9 Postcolonial and Subaltern Perspectives

Postcolonial power is not merely foreign rule; it also comprises the subordination of local life through knowledge, development, universities, law, finance and language. The contrast between Harvard's platform of ethics and the testimony of a leaf in Garh Narikel is especially meaningful. Prestigious global institutions seek to turn local suffering into an object of study, while the village reclaims its authority over knowledge.

Can the subaltern speak? The work answers not with one voice but with a collective archive. Workers, women, Dalits, the elderly, children and the dead speak through different media. Nevertheless, the role of educated intermediaries such as Aruni, Satyavrat and Meera is prominent, leaving open the question of how directly the subaltern voice is heard and how much it reaches us through representation. The novel acknowledges rather than wholly resolves this tension.

10.10 Ecocriticism

The river, soil, seed, fire, air, sky, trees, leaves and crocodiles are not mere settings, but active ethical presences. Water remembers, soil questions, ash testifies, air carries both rumours and smoke, and trees give the

community shade as well as records. This extends the boundaries of anthropocentric literature.

From the perspective of the blue and green humanities, the novel resists treating the river only as a resource. Water privatisation, seed theft, land acquisition and the politics of flooding raise questions of ecological justice.

A critical caution is necessary: although the 'crocodile' metaphor powerfully depicts institutional violence, it also risks turning an actual animal into a symbol of moral evil. In several places the work distinguishes the natural crocodile from its human counterparts; from an ecological perspective, however, the distinction could have been made clearer.

10.11 Reader-Response Theory

Blank plaques, empty pages, absent names, incomplete letters, silent recorders and the assertion 'The story has not ended' invite active reader participation. This structure corresponds to Wolfgang Iser's conception of 'gaps'. The reader must complete questions, remember names and make ethical judgements.

Yet at times the narrative immediately explains its own gaps. This reduces readerly freedom. Where a scene remains silent, the work is at its best; where every meaning is supplied with an explicit commentary, the reader's creative participation is restricted.

The supernatural here is indigenous rather than imported: the folk beliefs in ghosts, spirits, demons, loth, water-drowned souls and witches have already been presented with the authority of a lived tradition in the folk encyclopaedia of Chapter 0. Hence 'folk realism' is more appropriate than magical realism: the dead can become plaintiffs against injustices committed by the living. Episodes of digital arrest, voice imitation and mule accounts also connect the kādambarī with contemporary critiques of surveillance capitalism. The system that once struck names off lists now manufactures 'the voice of a name'.

11. Narrative Craft and Formal Design

The novel's structure is circular. The kabaddi game of Chapter 1 returns in the final chapter; the difference is that the dead play at the beginning and living children play at the end. Initially the dead demand justice; finally the living take over the vigil.

Each chapter's title, aphorism, folk song, narrative body and, frequently, philosophical undertone establishes a consistent rhythm. This lends the work an epic discipline. Repeated phrases—'The story has not ended', 'Name: Present', 'The crocodile devours the body, not the name'—function as refrains in oral storytelling.

The novel draws upon numerous genres: folktale, ghost story, mystery, social document, philosophical dialogue, song, letter, public hearing, dramatic reading, accusation, archival investigation, dream parable and children's game. This mixture of genres gives the work the breadth of a modern epic.

Metafiction is also significant. 'The Novel Begins Again' comments on its own narrative form. At the theatre festival, earlier chapters are dramatised. In the concluding chapter, all the chapter titles are read again. The text reflects on its making, rewriting and public use.

The author calls the work a 'Maithili kādambarī', and this designation is more than a label of genre. Appendix 3 narratively presents a classical debate about maṅgalavāda in relation to the final page of Bāṇabhaṭṭa's unfinished Kādambarī: the result of an auspicious invocation is not the completion of a book but the removal of obstacles. Thus the work connects itself both with Bāṇa's prose tradition and Mithila's Nyāya tradition. The architecture of each chapter—an aphoristic sentence, a chapter-opening folk song specifying its melody, prose narration, an oblique philosophical undercurrent and a concluding song—recalls both Sanskrit campū and folk dance-theatre.

12. Language, Folk Melodies and Stylistic Distinctiveness

The work's language creates a hybrid world of vernacular Maithili, scholarly terminology, bureaucratic expression, philosophical concepts and contemporary technological vocabulary. Brief aphoristic sentences are memorable: the river cuts away the embankment with its current, papers cut away the village with adjournments; taking a name to its home matters more than merely writing it down; the threshold is truth's first boundary of dignity; when help demands silence, a donation becomes a bargain.

Folk songs give the story orality, collectivity and rhythm. They are not mere decoration but instruments of labour, mourning, education, theatre and resistance. Women's songs and children's songs are particularly powerful bearers of communal knowledge.

The novel's imagery is often exceptionally effective: red tape is a water spirit's hair; a cupboard, the darkness of arrested time; dust, a clerk; a seal, a wound; a register, a map of fear; a green point in the stump. Such images make social abstractions palpable to the senses.

13. Social and Political Significance

The work questions the official narrative of development. Bridges, service, charity, technology, research and financial inclusion are all terms

associated with the public good; yet without names, consent, safeguards and accountability they can become covers for violence.

The question of caste is integral to the novel's fundamental architecture. Workers' names, the shared plate, kitchens, cremation grounds, touch, Gaṅgeśa's life and testimony from the supposedly lowest households all demonstrate that justice remains incomplete without an examination of caste.

The work is not simplistically opposed to digital modernity. Mobile phones, records, copies, messages and platforms serve both as instruments of crime and means of resistance. The issue is not technology itself but ownership, consent, transparency and communal use.

The novel proposes alternative forms of democracy: a constitution of names, public hearings, shared kitchens, investigations based on permission, copies held by the community, children's questions and vigilance over memory. It does not reject legal institutions; it holds that the community's voice is needed to give them human meaning.

14. Principal Achievements of the Work

First, a powerful joining of locality and globality. Garh Narikel's grove is linked to Harvard, Hong Kong, banks, digital platforms and global capital without losing its own folk perspective.

Second, an ethical philosophy of names. Modern literature discusses identity extensively, but here the name becomes central on legal, social, emotional, philosophical and spiritual levels alike.

Third, the conjunction of folk memory and the methods of evidence. Ghost stories are not superstition but metaphors of suppressed history; leaves become alternatives to paper, songs become archives and children's games become a jurisprudence.

Fourth, a serious treatment of consent and the right to one's image. The ethical questions concerning victims' stories, women's bodies, images of the dead, research and memorialisation receive unusually extensive treatment in a Maithili novel.

Fifth, its epic scope through the mixing of genres. The combination of the social novel, philosophical thought, mystery investigation, folk songs, theatre and dream parables is the work's distinctive signature.

Sixth, an unsimplified form of hope. At the end, not all criminals have disappeared and not every case has been resolved. Some criminals flee, some are arrested, and some shelter behind religion or illness. Hope resides not in the claim that the ‘problem is over’, but in the continued vigil.

15. Artistic Limitations and Critical Objections

Vastness is the work's strength, but its scale sometimes diminishes narrative density. Across 301 chapters, the recurrence of name, memory, silence, testimony, vigilance, leaf, crocodile and 'the story has not ended' produces a ritual effect; however, the constant repetition also places an extra burden of meaning upon the reader. Editing out repeated restatements of similar ideas would make the effect more acute.

The aphorism, song and philosophical conclusion attached to every chapter provide structural uniformity but sometimes produce formulaic writing. Where the scene itself makes its meaning clear, the final explanation appears unnecessary. From the standpoint of dhvani theory, more space could have been left for the reader to interpret.

Chapter Zero's extended account of folk culture matters for world-building, but such expansive essayistic material before the narrative begins delays the forward motion of the story. Distributing some of it through appendices or the narrative itself would have produced a more concentrated opening.

The philosophical undercurrents of Navya-Nyāya are original, yet when classical examples are only loosely connected with the story they resemble stand-alone textbook passages. Where narrative and philosophy are organically linked—non-apprehension, testimony, inference, consent and evidence—the effect is extraordinary; where philosophy is merely displayed, the narrative flow breaks.

Some antagonists gradually become schematic types as they represent social structures. More subtle depiction of their private lives, contradictions, self-deceptions, relationships and pace of change would have increased the ethical complexity. Their confessions sometimes follow a similar pattern: the remembrance of childhood humiliation, recognition of wrongdoing and incomplete remorse.

The novel's ethical position is clear and firm, but clarity sometimes dominates art. The reader generally understands early on whom to regard as right. More room for moral uncertainty, irony and complex choices by characters could have made the work more psychologically multilayered.

The supernatural is organic to the folk perspective, yet talking objects, letters emerging on leaves and direct intervention by the dead may blur the boundary between metaphor and event for some readers. The work usually treats these as the language of popular memory; nevertheless, restraint at certain points could have intensified the effect.

16. Overall Critical Judgement

The value of A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles lies not merely in its immense size or multiplicity of subjects, but in its original conception that justice for human beings is impossible unless the social life of their names is preserved. The work breaks the narrow assumptions that death is solely a biological event, injustice merely a legal case, technology merely a tool and memory a sentiment. Death is a crisis in the relations among paper, body, family, history and the future; injustice is a structural network; technology raises the ethical issue of ownership; and memory is public responsibility.

From the standpoint of Indian poetics, this is a folk epic moving from compassion through heroism towards an alert tranquillity, enriched by dhvani and vakrokti. From the standpoint of Navya-Nyāya, it is a novel of evidence from absence, the authority of testimony and the social application of inference. From the perspective of Western theory, it is a multilayered text of social totality, polyphony, archival power, biopolitics, trauma and memory, feminist consent, postcolonial knowledge and ecological justice.

Its limitations lie in excessive length, explanatory repetition, formulaic chapter design and the typification of several characters. Yet these limitations do not destroy its primary achievement. Rather, they show that the work takes the risk of becoming a vast communal archive instead of an elegantly bounded psychological novel. Its form is frequently uneven because it attempts to hold disparate voices, songs, documents, theories, memories and wounds within one body.

Ultimately the novel's highest achievement is the making of a new ethical proposition: justice is not only the punishment of offenders; it also consists of restoring forgotten names, respecting victims' consent, saving archives, teaching children to ask questions, sharing a plate and putting into words the silence within oneself. The final green point at Channa Gachhi symbolises the belief that so long as memory remains a communal undertaking, no crocodile will ever completely devour a human name.

17. Epilogue

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles is an ambitious, philosophical novel of folk life in modern Maithili literature. It tells the story of a village and thereby becomes the story of the world, without losing the village's speech, leaves, salt, earth and doorsteps in that vastness. Its final message is not reassurance but a call: read the names of the dead, hear the fears of the living, honour the ethics of evidence, and make justice a continuing vigil.

The work does not end, for beyond its final page the reader stands before the question of becoming the next watchkeeper.

Appendix

An Anthropological Compendium — All Three Volumes (0 · 1 · 2)

Key: 0 = Prehistory (−100 to −1) · 1 = Chapters 0 to 100 · 2 = Chapters 101 to 200

A · Category-wise List

Geographical Places — Villages, Hamlets, Mansions and Sites

Garh Narikel · Channa Gachhi · Coconut-Leaf School · Leatherworkers' Quarter · Musahari · Haripur Erosion · Thakur Mansion · Market in Bodies · Harihar Service Centre · Tetari Ghat · Imli Ghat · Old Bridge / Great Bridge · Harvard · Hong Kong · Meerut

Water Bodies — Rivers, Ponds, Wells, Reservoirs and Wetlands

Kamala-Balan · Ganga · Kosi · Twin Ponds · Pond of the Drowned · Dakahi Pond · Inner Pond · Dark River of Money · Well · Ahar (traditional reservoir) · Chaur (seasonal wetland) · Embankment · Small Pool

Trees and Plants

Channa Gachhi (Peepal / Witness Tree) · Coconut Tree · Mango · Tamarind · Bamboo · Bathua Greens

Animals and Other Creatures

Crocodile · Fish · Makhana (Fox Nut) · Elephant–Crocodile · Conch Shell · Snake · Tiger · Pigeon

People — Workers and the Dead (Principal)

Bisesar Paswan · Saryu Devi · Chhotu (Bholatun) · Salamat Ansari · Gopi Mahto · Rajnu Mandal · Kanhaiya · Shivnath Sada · Ujjwal Jha

People — Protagonists and Witnesses (Principal)

Nand Aruni · Ba · Aruni · Ananya · Ira Aruni · Meera (Mrinalini Arya) · Devika Sah · Phoolmati · Gop Kumar · Satyavrat Mehta · Soumya Ramanathan · Ramaiyya Subramanyam · Ishan Dutt · Ramlakhan · Madhav · Aditi

People — Offenders

Batuknath Hariharan · Chandrapal Batra · Raghav Somani ('Signal') · Lau Kin-Hung · Edward Broom · Mahavir Pathak · Malvika Green · Madhavesh

· Maheshwar · Dhruvesh · Shashibhushan Dev · Mahendra Pathak · Victor Halden · Divakar Lal

People — Other Characters and Register Names in Volume 2

Bhikhari Lal · Surmani Devi · Rani Devi · Dinbandhu and the Widow Ragini Devi · Phoolkali Devi · Ramratiya Devi · Jasoda Devi · Surajmukhi · Phulkunwari · Kamlu Paswan · Jagdish Mallah · Munna Paswan · Saurabh Mahto · Imran · Nageshwar Jha · Muniya · Dhanesari · Nagina

People — The Prehistory (Volume 0) and Philosophers

Mohan and Radhika · Sukhdev Mahto · Thompson Sah (Sahib) · Pratapsen · Kamala Devi · Gauri · Karu · Kalit · Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya · Vācaspati Miśra · Udayanācārya

Supernatural and Folk Characters

The Old Ghost · Hulasi · Water-Drowned Spirits · Loth · Demons · Witches · The Brahma of the Peepal Tree · Salhes

Folk Festivals, Rituals, Dances and Song Genres

Sohar · Samdaun · Vidapat · Batgabani · Chaiti · Phag · Nirgun · Marsiya · Jat-Jatin · Jhijhiya · Madhushravani · Aripan · Chapter-Opening Folk Song · Proverbs · Dhol · Mridang · Flute · Nagara Drum

Folk Justice and Communal Institutions

Ghost Kabaddi · Genealogical Register · Blue Register · Queen's Account · Service Register · Constitution of Names · Festival of Names · Night Assembly · Public Hearing · Women's Assembly · Roll of Silence · Guardians of Names

Objects and Symbols

Clay Plaque · Bronze Bowl (Three Waters) · Torn Gamchha · Iron Trunk · Iron Box · Three Pebbles (Home · Fear · Dream) · Leaf-Lamp · Lamp · Ritual Pitcher · Betel Leaf · Areca Nut · Vermilion · Paag Headgear · Dhoti · Gamchha · Splash (Sound)

Crops, Food and Caste Communities

Paddy · Makhana · Finger Millet · Sugarcane · Flattened Rice · Curd · Paswan · Musahar · Leatherworker · Ansari · Mahto · Mandal · Sada · Mallah

Philosophy, Classical Texts and Modern Phenomena

Navya-Nyāya · Tattvacintāmaṇi · Bhāmatī · Nyāyakusumāñjali · The Four Pramāṇas + Non-Apprehension · Digital-Arrest Scam · Mule Account · Voice Cloning · Surveillance Capitalism

B · Detailed Tables

Geographical Places — Villages, Hamlets, Mansions and Sites

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Garh Narikel	0·1·2	The novel's central village; a living world of memory, labour, water and caste.
Channa Gachhi	0·1·2	The site of a felled peepal grove; the dead's folk court and stage for ghost kabaddi.
Coconut-Leaf School	0·1·2	A children's school beside Channa Gachhi's stump; centre of the register of testimonies.
Leatherworkers' Quarter	0·1·2	A working community's quarter in the village; a site of caste inequality.
Musahari	2	The Musahar community's quarter; Chhotu's home.
Haripur Erosion	2	A village damaged by riverbank erosion; origin of the 'Queen's Account' in Rani Devi's episode.
Thakur Mansion	0	The mansion of Pratapsen and Kamala Devi; setting of the inner narrative in Volume 0.
Market in Bodies	1·2	A metaphorical location for the trafficking network; the episode of Phoolmati's liberation.
Harihar Service Centre	1·2	An investigative lead; entry point into the archival inquiry.
Tetari Ghat · Imli Ghat	2 · 0·1·2	Ghats on the Kamala-Balan; places of folk memory.
Old Bridge / Great Bridge	0·1·2	A road bridge built over the Ganga; site of labourers' water burial.
Harvard · Hong Kong · Meerut	0·1·2 · 0·1 · 0·1	External centres: ethical hypocrisy, global financial networks and crimes committed from afar.

Water Bodies — Rivers, Ponds, Wells, Reservoirs and Wetlands

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Kamala-Balan	0·1·2	The village river; source of flooding and erosion, and an ecological agent.
Ganga	0·1·2	The great river; site of the Great Bridge and workers' water burial.
Kosi	0	Mithila's river of sorrow; a reference point for memories of flooding.
Twin Ponds	0	Linked ponds; the site of water burial in the prehistory.
Pond of the Drowned	0·1·2	A pond associated with water-drowned spirits.
Dakahi Pond	0·1	The pond of the leaf-lamp episode (Chapter Zero's folk encyclopaedia).

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Inner Pond	0·1·2	A metaphor for deaths suppressed within a household: 'water burial without water'.
Dark River of Money	0·1·2	A metaphor for the secret financial flows of illegal accounts, mule accounts and donations.
Well · Ahar · Chaur · Embankment · Pool	0·1·2	The wells, traditional canals or reservoirs, low-lying wetlands, embankments and small pools of the village's water geography.

Trees and Plants

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Channa Gachhi (Peepal / Witness Tree)	0·1·2	A witness tree enduring for twelve hundred years; even after felling, its stump retains memory.
Coconut Tree	0·1·2	The tree from which the village takes its name.
Mango · Tamarind · Bamboo	0·1·2	Trees associated with names of ghats and the folk environment.
Bathua Greens	2	Greens growing from a crack beside the threshold; an image of remembered devastation (Surmani Devi's episode).

Animals and Other Creatures

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Crocodile	0·1·2	The reptile; central metaphor of time, oblivion, authority and capital—'the crocodile devours the body, not the name'.
Fish	0·1·2	Pond creatures; an image of words crossed out of the register ('little fish').
Makhana (Fox Nut)	1·2	An aquatic pond crop; part of the folk economy.
Elephant–Crocodile	0·1·2	The parable of elephant and crocodile; an episode of rescue through calling a name.
Conch Shell	0	The philosophical image of the shell–silver illusion (Navya-Nyāya).
Snake · Tiger · Pigeon	0·1·2	Creatures appearing in parables (rope and snake, a tiger subdued through yogic power, blue and white pigeons).

People — Workers and the Dead (Principal)

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Bisesar Paswan	1·2	Died at the bridge foundations; 'absent' in the register, his name is finally preserved.
Saryu Devi	1·2	A woman labourer; her thumbprint becomes the first lesson of justice.
Chhotu (Bholatun)	1·2	An underage Musahar boy; his real name is recovered through communal memory.
Salamat Ansari · Gopi Mahto · Rajnu Mandal · Kanhaiya · Shivnath Sada	1·2	Names of drowned workers reduced to anonymity on paper.

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Ujjwal Jha	১·২	Victim of a digital-arrest scam; his death plants the seed of the network's exposure.

People — Protagonists and Witnesses (Principal)

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Nand Aruni	০·১·২	The original witness; source of the 'three-copy testimony' principle.
Ba	১·২	The maternal voice; guardian of folk memory: 'An empty space also bears witness.'
Aruni · Ananya	০·১·২	The next generation; reading names, leading the village and safeguarding registers.
Ira Aruni	১·২	Born abroad; challenges Edward Broom at Harvard.
Meera (Mrinalini Arya)	১·২	A victim of invaded privacy; initiator of the 'right to one's image' forum.
Devika Sah	১·২	Ujjwal's sister; a courageous advocate for education against digital fraud.
Phoolmati	১·২	Freed from trafficking: 'My name is Phoolmati.'
Gop Kumar	০·১·২	Preserver of records, creator of the three-copy system and exposer of the network.
Satyavrat Mehta	০·১·২	An elderly advocate; reads aloud the names of the dead in court.
Soumya Ramanathan · Ramaiyya Subramanyam	১·২	Continuing investigative allies.
Ishan Dutt	১·২	A mysterious informant declared 'dead'; symbol of anonymous whistleblowers.
Ramlakhan · Madhav · Aditi	১·২	Supporting characters who examine the account registers; Aditi is Meera's love.

People — Offenders

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Batuknath Hariharan	১·২	A glittering Bar Council career, legal cunning and belated apology.
Chandrapal Batra	১·২	Operator of a mule-account network; the wound of a humiliated childhood name.
Raghav Somani ('Signal')	১·২	A voice-imitation network; guilt over deleting his mother's last voice recording.
Lau Kin-Hung	০·১	Hong Kong intermediary; nameless accounts and institutional defeat.
Edward Broom	১·২	International face of the bridge, drugs and gambling networks; 'development with human dignity'.
Mahavir Pathak	২	A concealed name from Batuknath's earlier period, brought out by the investigation.

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Malvika Green · Madhavesh · Maheshwar · Dhruvesh	1·2	Mid-level operators whose ultimate fates remain uncertain.
Shashibhushan Dev · Mahendra Pathak · Victor Halden · Divakar Lal	1	Corrupt officials from the beginning who later disappear from the story.

People — Other Characters and Register Names in Volume 2

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Bhikhari Lal	2	A village character in an episode about the weight of a lock: 'The breath inside is heavy.'
Surmani Devi	2	Mistress of the first home visited on the journey of repentance.
Rani Devi	2	An elderly woman of erosion-hit Haripur; the first name on the 'Queen's Account' (aged seventy-two).
Dinbandhu and the Widow Ragini Devi	2	Ragini Devi gives public testimony for the first time.
Phoolkali Devi	2	Distinct from Phoolmati; an episode about differentiating names in the archival register.
Ramratiya Devi · Jasoda Devi · Surajmukhi · Phulkunwari	2	Women's names inscribed in ledgers and name registers.
Kamlu Paswan · Jagdish Mallah · Munna Paswan · Saurabh Mahto · Imran	1·2	Names associated with registers and mule-account episodes.
Nageshwar Jha	2	A living litigant in the Channa Gachhi episode ('But he is alive').
Muniya · Dhanesari · Nagina	2	Names preserved in the 'Roll of Silence' and on clay plaques.

People — The Prehistory (Volume 0) and Philosophers

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Mohan and Radhika	0	Mohan the flautist; his grief for his daughter Radhika gives rise to the tradition of chapter-opening folk songs.
Sukhdev Mahto	0·1·2	Resident of the village's southern edge; chooses forgiveness rather than revenge.
Thompson Sah (Sahib)	0	A foreigner carrying a notebook; questions village elders ('The Sahib's Notebook').
Pratapsen · Kamala Devi · Gauri	0	Figures in the Thakur mansion's inner narrative; folk belief associated with Gauri's hand.
Karu · Kalit	0·1·2	Recurring folk characters from the prehistory and the main story.
Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya	0·1·2	Author of Tattvacintāmaṇi, founder of Navya-Nyāya and source of questions about the 'gateway to proof'.
Vācaspati Miśra · Udayanācārya	0	Authors of Bhāmatī and Nyāyakusumāñjali; basis of the philosophical drama in Volume 0.

Supernatural and Folk Characters

Name	Volume	Brief Description
The Old Ghost	0·1·2	A judge for twelve hundred years; ultimately hands over the staff to the living.
Hulasi	0·1·2	A spirit without hands; player in ghost kabaddi.
Water-Drowned Spirits · Loth · Demons · Witches	0·1·2	Souls of the prematurely dead in folk belief; members of the dead's tribunal.
The Brahma of the Peepal Tree	0·1·2	Folk deity inhabiting the witness tree.
Salhes	2	A Mithila folk deity and hero of oral epic; a folk-cultural reference.

Folk Festivals, Rituals, Dances and Song Genres

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Sohar · Samdaun	0·1·2	Folk songs celebrating birth and a daughter's departure or mourning.
Vidapat · Batgabani · Chaiti · Phag	0·1·2	Vidyapati's songs, journey melodies, seasonal songs and the rhythms of Phag.
Nirgun · Marsiya	0·1·2	Kabir's nirgun devotional voice and mournful marsiya elegy.
Jat-Jatin · Jhijhiya · Madhushravani	1·2	Folk dances and festivals of Mithila.
Aripan	1·2	The silent courtyard art of alpana; a sign of folk memory.
Chapter-Opening Folk Song · Proverbs	0·1·2	Folk-melody songs named at the dawn of every chapter, and aphoristic proverbs.
Dhol · Mridang · Flute · Nagara Drum	0·1·2	Folk musical instruments.

Folk Justice and Communal Institutions

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Ghost Kabaddi	0·1·2	The dead's folk court: ‘Cross the line, preserve your breath, return with a name.’
Register · Blue Register · Queen's Account · Service Register	0·1·2	The village's permanent record of names; a counter-archive distinct from criminal accounts.
Constitution of Names · Festival of Names	1·2	A communal code and celebration for protecting names.
Night Assembly · Public Hearing · Women's Assembly	0·1·2	Forms of collective justice.
Roll of Silence · Guardians of Names	1·2	The list of unspoken names and continuing vigilance over memory.

Objects and Symbols

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Clay Plaque	2	A commemorative tablet for one name at each of the grove's four sides.
Bronze Bowl (Three Waters)	2	Well water + Kamala-Balan + Ganga water: 'three kinds of testimony'.
Torn Gamchha	1·2	Not a sign of defeat, but a flag of labour, memory and courage.
Iron Trunk · Iron Box	1·2	Containers of sealed documentary evidence.
Three Pebbles (Home · Fear · Dream)	1·2	A principle of children's ethical education: three questions for each name.
Leaf-Lamp · Lamp · Ritual Pitcher	0·1·2	Leaf-lamps on Dakahi Pond; ritual lamps and ceremonial pitchers.
Betel Leaf · Areca Nut · Vermilion · Paag · Dhoti · Gamchha	0·1·2	Objects and garments of Maithili folk life.
Splash (Sound)	0·1·2	The sound of a body falling into water; the sonic mark of injustice.

Crops, Food and Caste Communities

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Paddy · Makhana · Finger Millet · Sugarcane · Flattened Rice · Curd	0·1·2	The village's crops and traditional foods.
Paswan · Musahar · Leatherworker · Ansari · Mahto · Mandal · Sada · Mallah	0·1·2	Working caste communities of the village; bearers of subaltern voices.

Philosophy, Classical Texts and Modern Phenomena

Name	Volume	Brief Description
Navya-Nyāya · Tattvacintāmaṇi	0·1·2	Mithila's tradition of logic and Gaṅgeśa's foundational text; tools for investigating injustice.
Bhāmatī · Nyāyakusumāñjali	0	Texts by Vācaspati and Udayana; foundations of the philosophical drama of Volume 0.
The Four Pramāṇas + Non-Apprehension	0·1·2	Perception, inference, comparison, verbal testimony and non-apprehension: categories for establishing testimony.
Digital Arrest · Mule Accounts · Voice Imitation · Surveillance Capitalism	1·2	Modern crocodiles of false-arrest scams, rented accounts, stolen voices and identity theft.

❖

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles — Criticism of the Complete Trilogy · Videha Parallel Literary Movement

69. The Ram Bharos Kapari ‘Bhramar’ Special Issue: Literary and Institutional Debates

Abstract

Some people, both in Nepal and in India, have reservations about Ram Bharos Kapari ‘Bhramar’ because of his association with the Madhesh movement, and therefore will not contribute to the special issue devoted to him. Yet the parallel literary stream is accustomed to such responses. Bhramar restored dignity to the proletarian classes at a time when Mahendra Malangia and caste-bound theatre were putting words such as sholkan and raar into plays built around slapstick humour. This made Bhramar's intervention all the more important.

Keywords: Bharos · Kapari · Bhramar · Special issue · Literary · Institutional · Debate

Abstract

Some people, on both the Nepalese and Indian sides, object to Ram Bharos Kapari ‘Bhramar’ because of his participation in the Madhesh movement and therefore decline to contribute. The parallel stream, however, is accustomed to this. The special issue has not received fewer contributions than any other issue.

Gajendra Thakur — Editorial for the New Issue

Ram Bharos Kapari ‘Bhramar’ conferred dignity on the proletarian classes. While Mahendra Malangia and casteist theatre were deploying the words *sholkan* and *raar* in plays based on slapstick humour, what Bhramar did was especially significant.

He travelled from Raipur to Guwahati. A *bhramar* is one who wanders.

2

The original author alleges that the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi is hypocritically perpetuating Professor Ramnath Jha's suppression of the social and genealogical background of Gangesha Upadhyaya.

For immediate reference, I reproduce the following extracts from my *Pañjī Prabandh*, Parts I and II:

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A source note states that this genealogical manuscript was subsequently uploaded in 2009 to Videha Pothi (www.videha.co.in) and Google Books.

The original genealogical references appear below:

Dūṣaṇa Pañjī — The Black Record

49.

21//10 From Chhādan: Jagadguru Gangesha, author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*.

188/2	Chamar woman	Mandar	Vabhaniyam	Chhadan
Gangesha, author of Tattvacintamani	Gangesha of Chhadan	Nai	Ratnakar's mother (unknown)	Gangesha
	Vallabha	Bhavai	Maheshwar	
			Jive	

From Chhādan: the author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*.

Gangesha's beloved was a woman of the Chamar community; five years after his father's disappearance/death, Gangesha, the author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, was born. The record says that he was a descendant of the Chamar woman Medhā.

From Chhādan: Mahāmahopādhyāya Gangesha, author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*.

"An account concerning Mahāmahopādhyāya Gangesha, author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, is available from an ancient *pañjī* [genealogical register]."

"Gangesha was born five years after his father had passed from sight": thus runs an ancient entry, recorded somewhere.

Devānanda Pañjī 39–2: From Chhādan, Jagadguru Guru Gangesha; from Vabhaniyām, Jayāditya, son of Sādhukar, and his wife.

Devānanda Pañjī 30=5: From Chhādan, the author of the *Upāya*, Mahāmahopādhyāya Vardhamāna; and from Khaṇḍvalā, Vishwanātha, son of Shivanātha, his wife, Gangesha; Mahāmahopādhyāya Vardhamāna / Supan / Harisharma.

3

In a book on Nagarjun—Yatri in Maithili—Kamalanand Jha credits him with giving Maithili literature a new direction. The original reviewer disagrees. For comparison, he cites Chandradhar Sharma Guleri's Hindi story *Usne Kaha Tha*: although an outstanding story, Guleri's literary output is limited, so crediting him with directing the whole Hindi short-story tradition on that basis alone would be an exaggeration. In the reviewer's judgment, Yatri's corpus in Maithili is smaller even than Guleri's. He refers to an observation by Rajkamal Chaudhary [Subhash Chandra Yadav, *Rajkamal: A Monograph*, p. 14]. Yatri's *Chitra* (25 poems) and *Patrahin Nagna Gachh* (44 poems) are mentioned; the latter received the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1968, after which, according to the original reviewer, Yatri's writing in Maithili almost came to a halt. On this basis, the claim of a sustained long-term influence is questioned. The author treats changes in Yatri's ideological life—going to Sri Lanka to become a Buddhist monk and, upon returning to his village, undergoing a second

sacred-thread ceremony to reassume a Brahmin identity—as evidence of ideological instability. The article then questions Kamalanand Jha's understanding of Maithili literature, recalling the authors of the parallel tradition alongside those of the mainstream (Annexures 1 and 2). On Vidyapati, the author alleges that Vidyapati Thakur, the Sanskrit–Avahaṭṭha writer, has been conflated with the lyricist Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishwar. He recommends the writings of the left-wing historian Vijay Kumar Thakur and says that his own essay on Vidyapati in Volume II of *Prabandh Nibandh Samalochana* addresses these questions. The Vidyapati depicted in the Videha logo, he states, is the pre-Jyotirishwar poet, as drawn by the artist Pank Lal Mandal, a recipient of the Videha honour.

Annexure 1

Chanda Jha (1831–1907), originally named Chandranath Jha, was born in Pindaruch village, Darbhanga. He was honoured with the titles Kavishwar and Kavichandra. He was Grierson's principal assistant in matters concerning Maithili. His works include *Mithila Bhasha Ramayan*, *Giti-Sudha*, *Maheshvani Sangrah*, *Chandra Padavali*, *Lakshmishwar Vilas*, *Ahalyacharita*, and a mixed prose-and-verse translation of Vidyapati's Sanskrit *Purusha-Pariksha*.

1

The house of justice is called the court;
Yet injustice fills the whole place.
Few there are who speak the truth;
All are intent on stealing others' wealth and hearts.
Deceit fills countless corners;
Whose dignity has it not diminished?
Says the poet 'Chandra': the court takes bribes;
All are complicit—whom, then, shall one blame?

2

By night and day, misery, O Bhola!
The cow, mother of the world, O Bhola,
Is slaughtered at the butcher's hand.
The magistrate has grown merciless, O Bhola;
Where shall we bow our heads?
No rain has come, O Bhola;
It has been an age since the clouds gave water.
By night and day, misery, O Bhola;
Life itself, in every body, hangs in doubt.
Village headmen flourish in comfort, O Bhola,

While the hungry poor wander in distress.
Who will endure the sidelong whispers, O Bhola,
That pass through the happy neighbourhoods?

3

Weapons have ceased to rule; lawsuits strike instead.
Brother hurls abuse at brother day after day.
The dishonest claim their rights by ruining the good.
Who can undo what fate has written on the brow?
I seek no wealth, no lovely women, no delicacies or jalebis;
Nor would I visit Indra's palace for diversion.
Merciful Goddess, this alone is my heart's desire:
To serve your lotus feet always with devotion.
Grain is dear; India falters—how will relief be found?
To the north and west, mountains and unbearable snow make the land impassable.
Opponents of religion loudly spread their wrong-headed doctrines.
Show your grace, Mother of the world, Tara of Mahishi.
What Mithila was, and what has she become?
The sage Yajnavalkya and the noble King Janaka—
Her knowledge and devotion have departed with them.
Vachaspati Mishra and the other world-teachers,
Who vanquished the disputes of Buddhists—
Has that Sharada departed for heaven?
Mislearning has increased its sport.
No one now cares for the rules of *varṇāśrama*;
Reverence for the Vedas is cast aside.
Worship, recitation, meditation and ritual gestures—
All have become games of deception.
Says Kavichandra: the court all day long
Inflicts suffering and sends many to prison;
Quarrels destroy both religion and wealth,
Servants of Kali's poverty and ruin.

4

What a dreadful age has come, O Shiva!
Cattle are in peril, religion declines—how long can the heart remain hard?
The company of the good is oppressed by rulers; thieves rejoice.
The earth swarms with those deemed low-born; little honour is paid to the high-born.
No one values religion, good conduct or affection; the wicked have the upper hand.

Even roots, tubers and fruit are scarce; grain has departed from the land.
No auspicious remedy succeeds; the mind is exhausted and bewildered.
Says Chandra: your grace alone, O Shiva, can end my sorrow.

5

Remember, remember, O mind, Shankara; know these times are terrible.
Whose heart is not stained when Kali rules through the king's hand?
One who serves Shiva, the compassionate, will not bring harm upon the people.
Know devotion as the wish-fulfilling creeper, a store of the supreme touchstone.
Do not become entangled in sensual objects; renounce them as improper.
Then in happiness, O 'Chandra', you will dwell at last in the realm of the crested Lord.

Annexure 2

1

Faturilal's Famine Poem / Verses on Famine

Faturilal's famine poem for the Fasli year 1281 (AD 1873–74)

[Grierson, *Maithili Chrestomathy and Vocabulary*]

Hear the story of the year eighty-one: / famine fell in every direction.
The rains failed that year; / how far can I describe the misery?
Rohini and the other rainy-season constellations / came and went as they pleased.
Mrigashira fulfilled only a little hope, / shedding a few light showers before leaving.
Ardra made an enormous show, / thundering on every side.
Pushya kept the earth's trees waiting / and turned away from the rains.
Punarvasu, held to be most auspicious, / was grudging with its rain as well.
Whatever seeds had sprouted / received only a scant, belated shower.
Magha became a miserly, barren season; / who in the world does not know it?
Purva gave no fullness and left nothing for the later rains; / whose story should I recount?
Uttara came and sat at home; / not even seven drops would fall.
Hathiya shut its horned head away; / even it was touched by decay.
Chitra showed no tenderness of heart; / it too became a plundering thief.
All the lunar mansions disgraced themselves; / the poor hid away in shame.
Those who came after reading astrology, / having mastered the geography of the earth,

Who knew geometry and algebra, / uttered only a few uncertain words.
They could not know the workings of Lord Rama's grace, / through which all deeds are done.
Whenever someone asked them about rain, / even they spoke in embarrassment.
When the rivers and streams were not replenished, / famine was bound to come.
Without water nothing sprouted in the world; / the earth herself was scorched.
The people who first sensed the approach of famine / were those who farmed the land.
Fate spared no side and favoured none; / it cut the rice crop at the root.
Neither *kodo* nor *marua* grew, / nor did any *sama* millet.
The young crops withered in their fields; / Providence had turned against us.
Who will protect the mortal world? / Where may one go in flight?
Even the netherworld is dried up; / everywhere there seems to be fire.
Shame upon that king Indra, / who withheld the waters!
Living creatures are distraught upon the earth; / no relief comes to them.
Neither winter crop nor *kheri* nor *chin* grew; / not a harvest could be seen.
In every household, men and women fretted; / the evil days had now begun.
The wealthy remained content in their minds, / keeping great stores in reserve.
They laughed, with rupees hidden in their homes, / while the price of a *ser* of grain rose.
Some bought *kurthi* or pulses / with the few coins they possessed.
Many kept fast after fast, / dreaming only of a meal of rice.
Some pooled their means to buy *janer* grain; / the poor could only sit and watch.
Two crops proved life-saving in that world: / pigeon pea and maize.
A terrible famine struck Tirhut; / its news spread everywhere.
In every house, men and women sought a little comfort / by chewing popped maize.
Landlords and moneylenders / still had heaps of grain in their houses.
Yet even they stared on helplessly, / their faces like those of the poor.
The merchants panicked at the sight of the times / and put up shutters in fear.
The shops of the towns fell silent; / the market stalls too were deserted.
Bodies grew thin, speech became confused; / how much suffering can one tell?

Men and women abandoned their adornments; / jewellery was now being sold.
Forehead ornaments, hairpins and earrings, / even nose studs no longer graced the nose.
Rings and toe rings, tiny tinkling ornaments, / armlets and bracelets were sold.
Moon-shaped necklaces, necklets and chains, / and beads of many kinds,
Suti, *navagraha* and *pachkhandi* ornaments, / down to the last *lashuni* piece.
Then not even household utensils were left; / fortune was utterly spent.
Pitchers, measures and spittoons, / neither basins nor trays remained.
Bowls, weights and betel boxes, / and the platters for eating,
Other utensils, even the finest household pieces, / nothing remained in the home.
Neither money, property nor house remained secure; / everything had been mortgaged.
Still hunger left nobody; / the stomach became an unfillable pit.
The Company descended as if by divine dispensation, / and Rama was its helper.
Hearing that Mithila was drowning in distress, / it hurried to the rescue.
It bought grain and loaded vessels, / filling sack after sack.
Tilanga soldiers were recruited at headquarters, / and Europeans disembarked.
Hundreds of thousands of measures at Hajipur, / and so many more at Patna;
At Bajitpur and Sultanpur depots, / who knows how much was stored?
Carts, oxen, wagons and camels moved through Bihar, / carrying all that grain.
At Mishra Kanhaiya's ponds / stood the first halting place.
King Lakshmishwar Singh, / the Maharaja of Mithila:
May the kingdom of Darbhanga remain steadfast; / may the Lord dispel its distress.
Ox-carts arrived by tens and hundreds of thousands, / with halts set along the road.
The first depots were Madhuban, Bhaura, / Jafra and Arer;
Benipatti and Pachmahala, / Kumhrauli and Kamtaul;
Hariharpur and Pindaruch—how shall I recount / how much work was done?
Baripokhar and Birsair, / and Pandoul, known to all;
Navhad, Sarisab and Bhatpura, / and farther south and upstream;
Jhanjharpur, Mahrail and Kanhauli, / with Madhepur an important centre;

Benipur, Kaman and Naraihi, / and let me name Phulparas;
Jhamna, known throughout the world, / Mahtha and Bachhaur;
Duhbi and Mahinathpur, / the work extended as far as Jainagar;
Baldevpur and Dhanga, / and the small market at Mirzapur;
Sibipatti and Kapsia, / and the headquarters depot at Saurath.
The officers came to Tirhut / to make provision for the poor;
Otherwise how many men and women would have died, / with children shrivelling away?
How many bodies would have mingled with the dust, / how countless lives would have gone!
Neither in-laws nor kinsmen could have saved them; / even those who supplied water might not have survived.
Everything everywhere seemed to change: / ponds, dust and roads alike.
Brahmins, scholars, Kayasths and Thakurs / remained distinct from one another.
Some had themselves registered as overseers; / some found employment as clerks.
In the name of charitable work they plundered rupees; / all began to profit.
Some escaped by furnishing bonds / when the officials were not upon them;
Others were beaten till their backs were broken, / bearing the punishment of a lifetime.
Some were abused until their bodies wasted; / many were sent away.
Parents and relatives wept at home: / their son had gone to prison.
Some houses were searched; / the clerk was found taking his share.
Some wailed in court; / others twirled their moustaches in arrogance.
Hearing of all this, the officer grew angry / and began appointing people to tasks.
The clerks were brought to shame, / their faces marked white with lime.
Among the Jog, Bikaua and ordinary lineages, / oaths and obligations multiplied.
Orchards, bamboo groves, oxen and buffaloes / became collateral or objects of dispute.
With that money came more noise and commotion, / and loans were taken through the court.
So many households fell into quarrels; / brothers and nephews separated.
The honourable Lieutenant-Governor arrived / at the sacred seat of Darbhanga.
With gentlemen and local notables / he assembled a committee.
.....
.....
.....

Sitting together with them, / the committee set to work.
A wonder of government enterprise: / the railway reached Tirhut.
They hurried to lay a road from Bajitpur, / rushing to the task.
They built bridges over the Hahaya and Gandak / and crossed the broad lowlands.
The Company, courageous and steadfast in duty, / was known, says Jagdishan.
By the pond at Lakshmi Sagar / it established a station.
The great Governor from Calcutta / sat with Shri Durga beside him.
The lesser lord from Agra / joined them, all seated together.
Commissioners and collectors gathered / and spoke without reserve.
These five sat upon the bench, / with the attendant party beside them.
News of Mithila's condition / reached the newspapers.
Hear us, foreign rulers, and come; / untangle the net of our sorrow.
Orders went to both Governors: / listen to our words.
Help the people, / why do you sit idle in comfort?
The high Governor called forth brave men, / officers and generals,
Majors, magistrates and collectors, / with colonels in attendance.
They procured grain from many lands, / paying everyone its price.
Mung beans, wheat and rice, / *bajra* and almonds,
From Doli, Patna and Bhatsar, / Delhi and Ajmer,
From Agra, Kanpur and Dhaka, / wherever grain lay in heaps.
The grain was dispatched to Tirhut, / piled upon carts and ox-wagons;
Elephants, horses, donkeys and carts, / accompanied by handsome soldiers.
Kshatriyas, Pathans, Mughals, / bold Rajput warriors—
Their splendour defied description, / like messengers of Hanuman.
At the head of the procession / marched the brave soldiers;
They carried spears and swords, / and bows and arrows in their hands.
They drilled on horseback / with their *jamadar* beside them.
Their appearance at that time / was beyond describing.
They worked in village after village, / amid broken roads and disorder;
Clearing crowds and groves, / they built roads and bridges.
In Patna district and Bhatsar, / within the Mahisaur *pargana*,
There lived a worthy man, / to whose house Lakshmi hastened.
Shri Dwarika Prasad, / devout and wise,
A distinguished court *tehsildar*, / known throughout the world.
Babu Ishwari Prasad of Diwati / came to Madhuban;
He instructed the superintendent / to visit every hamlet.
Many received substantial provisions, / and many took charitable relief.
Blessed, blessed be the British officers: / everyone's body found sustenance.

Poor and rich, all shouted victory, victory; / Brahmins offered blessings.
May the rule of Shri Raghunath increase; / may its throne endure a hundred thousand years.
The poet Fatur Lal recounts / the misery of this famine.
May the Governor and Government officers / keep Tirhut flourishing.

2

Radhakrishna Chaudhary, *History of Mithila* (available in the Videha archive)

"The famine of 1770 was unprecedented in the history of Mithila, and its population was reduced drastically. In 1873–74 Mithila experienced another famine of the same kind, described in Faturi Lal's *Akali Kavitt*, a poem on famine which has not been published. At the time, a railway project was undertaken both to relieve the famine and to give employment to labourers. Faturi Lal writes of the railway:

'The Company made a marvel of a machine, / fashioned with extraordinary grandeur.
Outstripping the wind, / it was set loose upon the plains.
Leaving its station, it rushed through the middle, / running at tremendous speed;
People scattered aside and stood away, / clearing its path.
The telegraph brought repeated news, / of every kind and from afar;
The ticket-holder grew alert: / the railway was coming.
It made a strange roaring sound; / where could one see its end?
Its machinery thundered so forcefully, / such was the greatness of the engine.
Guards, compartments and all the fittings / were astonishing to behold;
Filled with coal, the engine / sent smoke flying upwards.
A single whistle began to sound, / like the cry of an elephant;
Those who climbed aboard found / a place according to their station.
Crossing the full stream of the Ganges, / Fatur reached the other bank by train;
This is the astonishing poem / he composed about that wondrous thing.'

70. Dalit Discourse and Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar (1891–1956)

Abstract

From that village came the family of Ramji Sakpal, who served as headmaster of a school in the Indian Army. Gaurangi Nilakshi and Bhima are named as his wives. His fourteenth child was born to Bhima on 14 April 1891 and was named Bhim; Ramji was then posted at Mhow…

Keywords: Babasaheb Ambedkar; Dalit discourse; education; social justice; biography; history

1

Ratnagiri is a town in Maharashtra. Near it lies a village called Ambavade.

A family from this village was that of Ramji Sakpal, who was headmaster of a school in the Indian Army. Gaurangi Nilakshi and Bhima are named as his wives. His fourteenth child was born to Bhima on 14 April 1891, and he was named Bhim. Ramji was posted at Mhow at that time.

In 1894 Ramji retired from service. Bhim was only six when his mother died, and thereafter his disabled elder sister cared for him. His father remarried and went to Goregaon in search of employment.

2

Ramji Sakpal belonged to the untouchable Mahar caste. He would wake Bhim early in the morning for his studies by reciting couplets of Kabir.

After retiring, when he came to Camp-Dapoli in 1894, the municipal education department of Dapoli decided not to admit untouchable children into its schools. Until then, such children had been admitted there. Ramji consequently moved to Mumbai and then Satara. Bhim's early schooling took place in Satara.

No barber would cut Bhim's hair, so his sister cut it for him.

At school nobody would sit close to him.

The driver of a horse-cart would let him ride only on the condition that Bhim himself drove while the driver sat at ease.

Even drinking water was a problem: were water sources not meant for him?

“I shall acquire an education; then all these things will become available to me.” Bhim made this resolution.

There were two teachers at that school, Pendse and Ambedkar.

One day Bhim deliberately got himself wet so that he would not have to attend school. But Pendse sent him to his own home, and Bhim had to put on a *dhoti* and return to his lessons.

Bhim became teacher Ambedkar's favourite pupil. Ambedkar was a Brahmin. One day Bhim had brought no food and was sitting alone beneath the shade of a tree, hungry.

Ambedkar asked, "Bhim, why are you sitting here alone?" Bhim explained that he had brought no lunch. "What of it?" Ambedkar replied. "Come; today teacher and pupil shall eat *roti* and vegetables together." No one had ever treated Bhim with such kindness. He was overjoyed.

Ambedkar said, "Bhim, I give you my family name. From now on you shall be known as Ambedkar."

3

Ramji moved to Mumbai. Bhim was enrolled at Elphinstone School. He completed his schooling in 1907. Keluskar presented him with a copy of *Buddhacharitam*.

Bhim longed to study Sanskrit at school, but permission was refused.

When Bhim was seventeen, he married Rama, who was nine years old.

Through the efforts of Mr Keluskar, Bhim received a scholarship from the ruler of Baroda; he passed his BA in 1912.

The Baroda government appointed him to the rank of lieutenant.

Thereafter his father's health deteriorated. Bhim returned to see him, and his father was happy to see his son. He departed this life in that happiness; Bhim wept bitterly at his death.

4

With a scholarship from the ruler of Baroda, Bhim left for New York in 1913 to study. Columbia University accepted his dissertation and awarded him the degree of Doctor of Philosophy.

Bhim returned home.

His friends and relatives decided that he should be honoured with a grand public reception.

But he refused the honour. "Use the money that would be spent on my reception to provide scholarships and educate the deprived."

The ruler of Baroda summoned him to Baroda and ordered that arrangements be made for his lodging and meals.

But no eating-house or *dharamshala* was willing to accommodate him. A Parsi guesthouse allowed him to stay for a few days, but he was eventually expelled from there too.

He began to weep beneath a tree. "I had thought that if I became educated, this fault attributed to me would disappear. But I have acquired an education now. Why am I still being subjected to such suffering? I swear that I shall break this system and strike at its roots."

5

Bhim returned to Mumbai and became a professor at Sydenham College.

Chhatrapati Shahu Maharaj of Kolhapur was committed to uplifting the marginalised. Bhim visited him. At Mangaon, Shahu Maharaj proclaimed, "O people who have been neglected, your liberator has arrived—Dr Ambedkar!"

Yet another blow followed: after the death of their son Gangadhar, his wife Rama grew grief-stricken. She continued to care for Yashwant. Her husband spent very little time at home, but she endured it all.

6

He then resigned from teaching and submitted a dissertation on *The Problem of the Rupee* to a London institution named "Economic and Political Science". He was regarded as a revolutionary, however, and therefore submitted a revised dissertation in the form the institution wanted, returning with the degree of Doctor of Science. After studying law, he also began to practise in the courts.

On 20 July 1924 he founded an organisation called the Bahishkrit Hitakarini Sabha. He believed that people must resolve their own problems; others would not do it for them.

7

8

71. The Kamalanand Jha Affair: Pseudo-Criticism in Maithili

Abstract

The title of Kamalanand Jha's book Maithili Upanyas: Samay, Samaj aur Sawal (Maithili Novels: Time, Society and Questions, 2021) is misleading. It is a collection of a few syndicated, supposedly critical essays on certain upper-caste novelists. Its 263-page hardbound edition can only be sold to libraries, where it will decay. I bought it on Amazon for 405 rupees, but in my view it contains material not worth even five paise. One correction is necessary: without reading Gulo, a novel by the non-upper-caste writer Subhash Chandra Yadav, he disposed of it in two lines. I reproduce those two lines here for your amusement.

Keywords: Kamalanand Jha; Maithili novel; critical method; Gulo; literary controversy; textual criticism; allegations of plagiarism

The title of Kamalanand Jha's Maithili Upanyas: Samay, Samaj aur Sawal (Maithili Novels: Time, Society and Questions, 2021) is misleading. It is a collection of several syndicated, purportedly critical essays on certain upper-caste novelists. This 263-page book, in hardback, can only be sold to libraries, where it will rot away. I paid 405 rupees for it on Amazon, but it does not, in my judgement, contain material worth even five paise.

One correction is in order. Without reading Gulo, the novel of the non-upper-caste author Subhash Chandra Yadav, Jha wrote two lines and dismissed it. I reproduce those lines here for your amusement. You may already have read Gulo; if not, read it first, for the experience will then be even more amusing. With Subhash Chandra Yadav's permission, Gulo is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

"The novel's weakness is the author's political prejudice. Partisanship towards a particular politics cannot do justice to a work of literature."

Where politics is nowhere to be found in a novel, there can be no question of "political prejudice" or "partisanship towards a particular politics". Dhumketu and Yatri made use of the language of political prejudice and partisanship. Subhash Chandra Yadav's Bhot, published in 2022 and available with his permission in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm, does deal with politics; yet even there, his Bhagat-style narration has no need of the crutch of political prejudice or partisanship. Read my book Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav, available at the same address.

Kamalanand Jha's Brahmanical caste prejudice against Subhash Chandra Yadav, without having read his work, sounds a warning bell. The Parallel

Stream is alert to the way Jha, as I see it, adopts the guise of leftism to advance Brahmanism and sacrifice social justice. Landholders became communists to escape land-ceiling laws; now others seek shelter in leftism to protect Brahmanism. People of this kind have, in the author's view, inflicted great damage on communism.

(With Subhash Chandra Yadav's permission, his entire literary output is available in the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.)

In his biographical note he proudly mentions a Sahitya Akademi assignment to translate into Maithili—an assignment, I contend, obtained by depriving a non-upper-caste person of an opportunity and denying the rightful claims of writers from the Parallel Stream. This assignment, in my assessment, came not through merit but through a caste-marked surname and such manoeuvres. For people like him, Maithili is one line in a résumé; for the Parallel Stream, it is a question of life and death.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein is a historical autobiography of the Kosi River. He has written historical accounts of other rivers of Mithila as well: Bandini Mahananda; Bagmati Ki Sadgati!; Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein... (Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani); Na Ghat Na Ghar; Bagawat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi; Bhutahi Nadi Aur Takniki Jhar-Phunk; The Kamla River and People on Collision Course; Bhutahi Balan: Story of a Ghost River and Engineering Witchcraft; and Refugees of the Kosi Embankments. I allege that Pankaj Jha Parashar, a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board, translated paragraphs from these books into Maithili and published them under his own name as a novel—work that the pseudo-critic Kamalanand Jha then describes as this novelist's "research". Let me make clear that this writer, whom I accuse of theft, and the critic I call a pseudo-critic both belong to the Hindi Department at Aligarh Muslim University. The research is Dinesh Kumar Mishra's. He earned a BTech in Civil Engineering from IIT Kharagpur in 1968 and an MTech in Structural Engineering in 1970, and is qualified to carry out such research. People sometimes enrol in Hindi when they are exhausted by the failure to gain admission elsewhere; otherwise, Kamalanand Jha might have understood that this research could only have been carried out by a civil engineer. Perhaps he did understand it. Screenshots from the Hindi original and the Maithili text are appended below.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not from Mithila, yet he has written the histories of all its rivers. We are grateful to him, and the people of Mithila will never be able to discharge this debt. Once again, however, the author argues, those greedy for mainstream awards and money have shown ingratitude. Ten or twelve years earlier, Taranand Viyogi had come to Pankaj

Parashar's defence, writing, in effect, that Parashar became so influenced by others that their material inadvertently entered his own work. Now Parashar has sought Kamalanand Jha's protection—but unfortunately for him the Parallel Stream is conscious of what, in the author's view, is Jha's use of leftism to promote Brahmanism at the expense of social justice. Landowners once turned communist to avoid land ceilings; some now shelter under leftism to defend Brahmanism. Such people have caused immense harm to communism.

All of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's books are now available in the Videha archive with his permission:

http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm

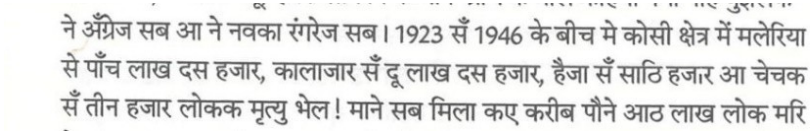
Recall, at this point, that when Bill Gates was asked whether the Xbox was being introduced late in India because of fears of piracy, he replied that Microsoft had never delayed the launch of any product for fear of piracy. Despite risks of this sort, therefore, we shall keep enriching the Videha archive. One rotten fish does not spoil every fish in the pond of the Parallel Stream. The fisherfolk here have been removing the rotten fish one by one, and will continue to do so.

I recommend two books to clear Kamalanand Jha's mind and vision. He should read the first, Sushil's Gambaali (novel, 1982), and the second, my Dushan Panji: The Black Book. Both are available at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm. When my review of Sushil begins, I shall offer Jha the lesson I have reserved for him there.

A final blow against syndicated criticism.

I shall keep an eye on this pseudo-critic, Kamalanand Jha.

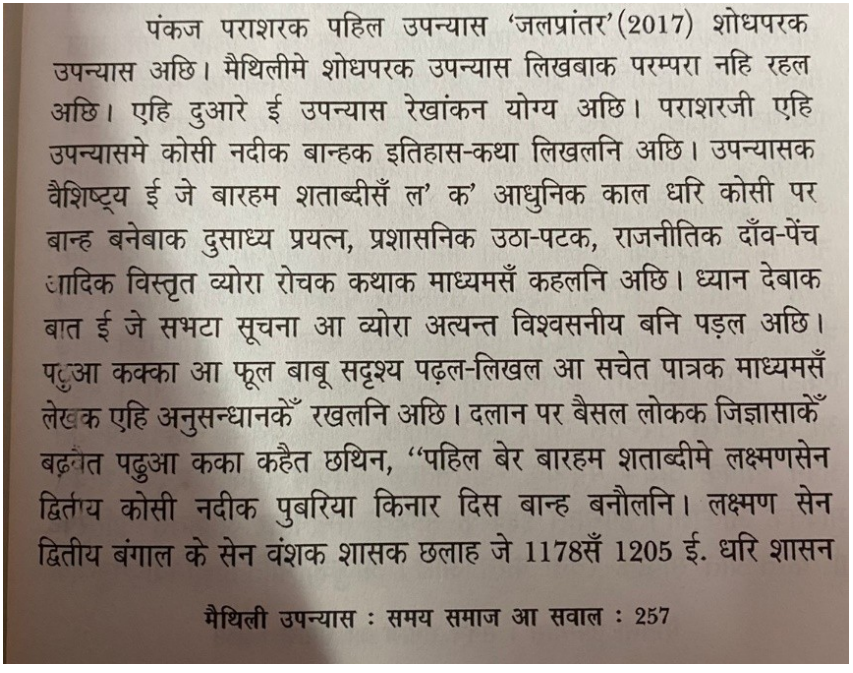
Original, Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein..., 2006): "It is worth noting that between 1923 and 1946, 510,000 people died of malaria in the Kosi region, 210,000 of kala-azar, 60,000 of cholera, and 3,000 of smallpox—a total of 783,000 deaths."
Pankaj Jha Parashar, accused here of plagiarism [Jalprantar, 2017, p. 103]:


ने अँग्रेज सब आ ने नवका रंगरेज सब। 1923 सँ 1946 के बीच मे कोसी क्षेत्र में मलेरिया
से पाँच लाख दस हजार, कालाजार सँ दू लाख दस हजार, हैजा सँ साठि हजार आ चेचक
सँ तीन हजार लोकक मृत्यु भेल! माने सब मिला कए करीब पौने आठ लाख लोक मरि

English rendering of the visible facsimile (Jalprantar, p. 103): The excerpt mentions deaths in the Kosi region between 1923 and 1946, including 510,000 from malaria, 210,000 from kala-azar, 60,000 from cholera and 3,000 from smallpox, for a total of 783,000. The image is reproduced to document the textual comparison.

Original, Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein..., 2006): "In Bihar, India, the Kosi River was embanked in the twelfth century by a king named Lakshman II. For this he received the title 'Bir' from his subjects, and the embankment came to be called 'Bir Bandh'. Traces of this embankment can still be seen some five kilometres south of Bhimnagar in Supaul district. Dr Francis Buchanan (1810–11) conjectured that the structure might have been the outer wall protecting a fort, because it extended for thirty-two kilometres along the western bank of the Dhaus River, as far as its confluence with the Tilyuga. Dr W. W. Hunter (1877) did not agree with Buchanan's view that it was a fortification wall. Citing local people, Hunter said that most did not think it was a fort wall; they thought it was something else, though he could not say with certainty what. The prevailing view, however, is that it was an embankment built along the Kosi to prevent the river from shifting westwards. People also said it appeared that work on the embankment had been stopped abruptly."

Kamalanand Jha, called a pseudo-critic here, praises the novelist whom I accuse of plagiarism. See the passage he quotes from Pankaj Jha Parashar (Maithili Upanyas: Samay, Samaj aur Sawal, pp. 257–58):

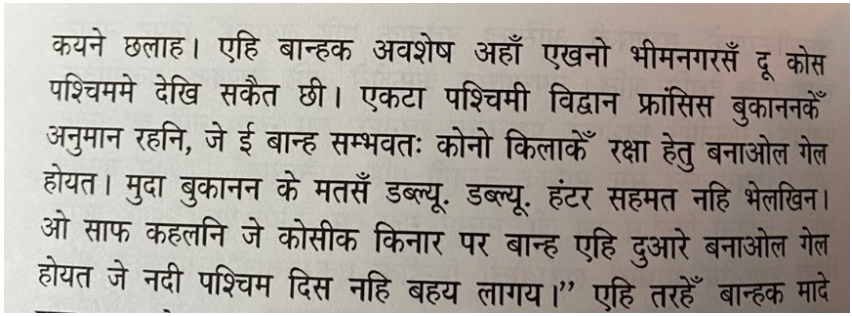


पंकज पराशरक पहिल उपन्यास 'जलप्रांतर' (2017) शोधपरक उपन्यास अछि। मैथिलीमे शोधपरक उपन्यास लिखबाक परम्परा नहि रहल अछि। एहि दुआरे ई उपन्यास रेखांकन योग्य अछि। पराशरजी एहि उपन्यासमे कोसी नदीक बान्हक इतिहास-कथा लिखलनि अछि। उपन्यासक वैशिष्ट्य ई जे बारहम शताब्दीसँ ल' क' आधुनिक काल धरि कोसी पर बान्ह बनेबाक दुसाध्य प्रयत्न, प्रशासनिक उठा-पटक, राजनीतिक दाँव-पेंच आदिक विस्तृत व्योरा रोचक कथाक माध्यमसँ कहलनि अछि। ध्यान देबाक बात ई जे सभटा सूचना आ व्योरा अत्यन्त विश्वसनीय बनि पड़ल अछि। पढुआ कक्का आ फूल बाबू सदृश्य पढ़ल-लिखल आ सचेत पात्रक माध्यमसँ लेखक एहि अनुसन्धानकेँ रखलनि अछि। दलान पर बैसल लोकक जिज्ञासाकेँ बढ़बैत पढुआ कका कहैत छथिन, "पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दीमे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मण सेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह जे 1178सँ 1205 ई. धरि शासन

मैथिली उपन्यास : समय समाज आ सवाल : 257

English rendering of the visible facsimile (Kamalanand Jha, Maithili Upanyas: Samay, Samaj aur Sawal, p. 257): "Pankaj Parashar's first novel, Jalprantar (2017), is a research-based novel. Maithili has no tradition of writing research-based novels; for this reason the book deserves attention. In this novel Parashar writes a historical narrative of

embankments on the Kosi River. Its distinctive feature is that, through an engaging story, it gives an extensive account of the arduous efforts to build embankments on the Kosi from the twelfth century to modern times, administrative upheavals, political manoeuvres and the like. What deserves attention is that the information and details seem remarkably credible. Through literate and alert characters such as Padhua Kakka and Phul Babu, the author presents this research. As the curiosity of the people sitting on the veranda increases, Padhua Kakka says: 'The first embankment was built on the eastern bank of the Kosi in the twelfth century by Lakshman Sen II. Lakshman Sen II was a ruler of Bengal's Sena dynasty, who ruled from AD 1178 to 1205 ...'"



कयने छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगरसँ दू कोस
पश्चिममे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकाननकेँ
अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह सम्भवतः कोनो किलाकेँ रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल
होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मतसँ डब्ल्यू. डब्ल्यू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन।
ओ साफ कहलनि जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल
होयत जे नदी पश्चिम दिस नहि बहय लागय।" एहि तरहेँ बान्हक मादे

English rendering of the continuation of the visible facsimile: "'... You can still see the remains of that embankment two kos west of Bhimnagar. A Western scholar, Francis Buchanan, conjectured that it may have been made to protect a fort. But W. W. Hunter disagreed with Buchanan. He stated plainly that the embankment beside the Kosi had been constructed to keep the river from flowing westwards.' In this way, concerning the embankment ..." [*The photographed excerpt ends mid-sentence.*]

Pankaj Jha Parashar, accused here of plagiarism [Jalprantar, 2017, p. 31]:

पढ़ुआ कका पछिला गप कें आगाँ बढ़बैत कहलखिन, 'फूल बाबू, कोसी नदीक बेसिन प्राचीन काल सँ मनुक्खक निवास लेल उपयुक्त स्थान रहल अछि। बारहम-तेरहम सदी मे भारत मे जखन कइक टा नदी सुखा गेल, तँ ओहि ठामक पशुचारक समाजक लोक एतय आबि कए बसलाह। तहिये सँ बढ़ैत जनसंख्या आ कोसी नदीक बदलैत प्रवाहक मध्य टकराहटि होमय लागल। नदीक अनियंत्रित धारा कें लोक बाढ़ि बूझय लागल। पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दी मे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह, जे 1178 सँ 1205 ईस्वी धरि शासन कयनें छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगर सँ दू कोस पश्चिम मे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकानन के अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह संभवत: कोनो किला के रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मत सँ डब्लू. डब्लू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलखिन, जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत, जे नदी पच्छिम दिस नहि बह' लागय।' पढ़ुआ कका सँ मुँहजबानी एतेक रास ऐतिहासिक तथ्य सुनियो कए फूल बाबू सहमति मे मूड़ी नहि डोलेलखिन। जाहि सँ ओतय बैसल लोक सबहक उत्सुकता और बढ़ि गेलनि, जे गप मे एहेन कोन तथ्य रहि गेलै जे फूल बाबू संतुष्ट नहि भेलखिन? लोक कें बुझेलनि जे फूल बाबू शास्त्रार्थ के अखड़हा पर माटि फेकि रहल छथिन। पढ़ुआ कका कें आइ जोड़ीदार भेटि गेलनि!

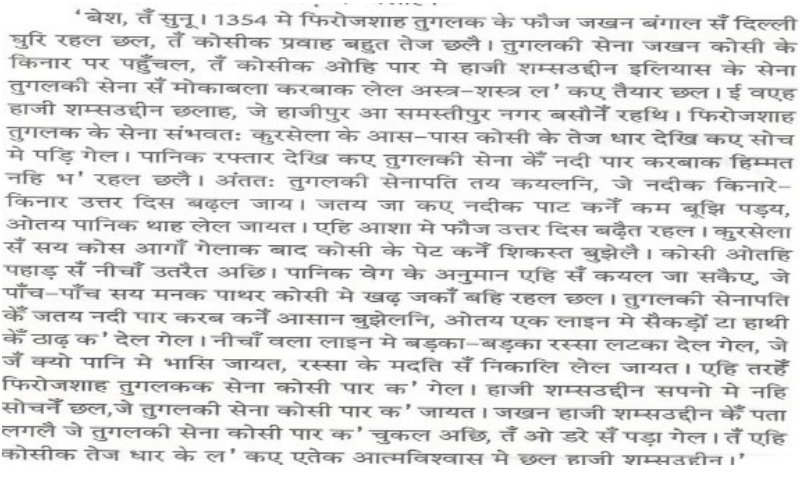
जलप्रांतर / 31

English rendering of the visible facsimile (Jalprantar, p. 31): "As Padhua Kakka continued his account, he said: 'Phul Babu, from ancient times the banks of the Kosi River have offered people a suitable place to settle. When several rivers dried up in India during the twelfth and thirteenth centuries, their pastoral communities settled here and began farming. With the increase in population, collisions began to occur between the changing course of the Kosi and human settlement. The river's uncontrolled flow caused growing hardship. The first embankment on the eastern bank of the Kosi was built in the twelfth century by Lakshman Sen II. Lakshman Sen II was a Sena ruler of Bengal, ruling from 1178 to 1205. Remains of the embankment can still be seen two kos west of Bhimnagar. A Western scholar, Francis Buchanan, believed it might have been built to defend a fort; W. W. Hunter did not agree with him and stated clearly that the embankment was built on the Kosi to prevent the river moving west.' Padhua Kakka was putting these historical facts before the assembly. Phul Babu grew stubborn and would not accept what the elderly men had said. What, he asked, had the authorities done when the flood came? The people hurled mud at Phul Babu's stubbornness. Several readers arrived at Padhua Kakka's place."

Original, Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein..., 2006): "The terrifying force of the Kosi can be glimpsed in the account of Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army returning from Bengal to Delhi in 1354. It is said that, when the Sultan's forces reached the Kosi, they saw Haji Shamsuddin

Ilyas's army standing on the opposite bank, ready for battle. This was the same Haji Shamsuddin who founded the towns of Hajipur and Samastipur. Firoz's forces appear to have halted somewhere near Kursela, unsure what to do. The speed of the river barred their advance. Eventually they decided to travel north along its bank, taking soundings wherever a crossing seemed possible. The Sultan's army advanced nearly one hundred kos upstream and crossed near Jiyaran, at the point where the river descended from the mountains to the plains. Though the river was narrower there, its current was so fierce that huge boulders weighing five hundred maunds were swept downstream like straws. At the place where a crossing seemed feasible, the Sultan stationed rows of elephants on both sides, suspending ropes from the lower row to rescue anyone carried away by the current. Shamsuddin had never imagined that the Sultan's army could cross the Kosi. On learning that it had succeeded, he fled."

Pankaj Jha Parashar, accused here of plagiarism [Jalprantar, 2017, p. 105]:



'बेश, तँ सुनू। 1354 मे फिरोजशाह तुगलक के फौज जखन बंगाल सँ दिल्ली घुरि रहल छल, तँ कोसीक प्रवाह बहुत तेज छलै। तुगलकी सेना जखन कोसी के किनार पर पहुँचल, तँ कोसीक ओहि पार मे हाजी शम्सउद्दीन इलियास के सेना तुगलकी सेना सँ मोकाबला करबाक लेल अस्त्र–शस्त्र ल' कए तैयार छल। ई वएह हाजी शम्सउद्दीन छलाह, जे हाजीपुर आ समस्तीपुर नगर बसौनैं रहथि। फिरोजशाह तुगलक के सेना संभवतः कुरसेला के आस–पास कोसी के तेज धार देखि कए सोच मे पड़ि गेल। पानिक रफ्तार देखि कए तुगलकी सेना कैं नदी पार करबाक हिम्मत नहि भ' रहल छलै। अंततः तुगलकी सेनापति तय कयलनि, जे नदीक किनारे–किनार उत्तर दिस बढ़ल जाय। जतय जा कए नदीक पाट कनैं कम बूझि पड़य, ओतय पानिक थाह लेल जायत। एहि आशा मे फौज उत्तर दिस बढ़ैत रहल। कुरसेला सँ सय कोस आगाँ गेलाक बाद कोसी के पेट कनैं शिकस्त बुझेलै। कोसी ओतहि पहाड़ सँ नीचाँ उतरैत अछि। पानिक वेग के अनुमान एहि सँ कयल जा सकैए, जे पाँच–पाँच सय मनक पाथर कोसी मे खढ़ जकाँ बहि रहल छल। तुगलकी सेनापति कैं जतय नदी पार करब कनैं आसान बुझेलनि, ओतय एक लाइन मे सैकड़ों टा हाथी कैं ठाढ़ क' देल गेल। नीचाँ चला लाइन मे बड़का–बड़का रस्सा लटका देल गेल, जे जँ क्यो पानि मे भासि जायत, रस्सा के मदति सँ निकालि लेल जायत। एहि तरहेँ फिरोजशाह तुगलकक सेना कोसी पार क' गेल। हाजी शम्सउद्दीन सपनो मे नहि सोचनैं छल,जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' जायत। जखन हाजी शम्सउद्दीन कैं पता लगलै जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' चुकल अछि, तँ ओ डरे सँ पड़ा गेल। तँ एहि कोसीक तेज धार के ल' कए एतेक आत्मविश्वास मे छल हाजी शम्सउद्दीन।'

English rendering of the visible facsimile (Jalprantar, p. 105): "'Brother, listen. In 1354, as Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army was returning from Bengal to Delhi, it reached the bank of the Kosi. There it encountered the army of Haji Shamsuddin Ilyas, ready to fight on the other side. The Kosi's swift current kept the Sultan's troops from advancing. They resolved to move north along the bank until they found a place to cross. After travelling some hundred kos, they reached a crossing near Jiyaran. There the river was narrow but its flow so violent that huge boulders were swept away like straw. The Sultan had elephants arranged in lines on either side of the crossing and ropes hung below, so that anyone carried away could be rescued. Shamsuddin had never expected the Sultan's army to cross the river; when he learned that they had done so, he fled.'" [Only the portion visible in the photographed excerpt is rendered here.]

Comments by Maithili writers on the Kamalanand Jha controversy

.....

Who is the novelist—Pankaj Parashar (the novel Jal Prantar)?

Sad.

RabindraChaudhary

.....

Extremely unfortunate, objectionable and criminal conduct.

KumarManojKashyap

.....

I am deeply troubled after reading all this.

R N Mishra

.....

Unfortunate.

Kalpna JhaPatna

.....

Good heavens! Then who is this person?

Pankaj Parashar (the novel Jal Prantar).

Oh God! So he really is a thief.

Umesh Mandal

.....

Gaurinath:

Good. It is necessary to expose such a thief.

Pankaj Parashar (the novel Jal Prantar).

His entire literary career rests on theft, and there is no shortage in Maithili of people willing to patronise him.

.....

Such thieves are always in the forefront when it comes to harming Maithili and Mithila.

JhaPrasanna

.....

He should be taken to court.

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi

+91 98310 37532

.....

SubhashChandraYadav: I condemn it. The thief must be exposed.

.....

Extremely sad and reprehensible.

ManojPathak

.....

Respectful thanks.

He could have quoted it; but the source must be acknowledged. Otherwise it is considered literary plagiarism.

RamanandMandal

.....

Thank you.

VidehaKeshavBhardwajDelhi

.....

Nabo Narayan Mishra

An unfortunate situation.

.....

Mukund Mayank

Oh

.....

Pradeep Pushp

A very bad thing.

.....

Abhilash Thakur ·

A despicable act! Shameful.

.....

Ajit Kumar Jha

One wonders whether people with such tendencies have any sense of shame. A separate award ought perhaps to be announced for such people as well. Congratulations to you for exposing them.

.....

Ramesh Kumar Sharma

Perhaps he was in a hurry to receive an award.

.....

Kunal

Announce the name of the novel and its author.

.....

Ashish Anchinhar

Kunal-ji, if an ordinary reader had asked this question, I would have welcomed it.

When such a question comes from enlightened readers and writers, it means the situation has become grave. In any case, since you have asked, here is the answer: the book is Jalprantar, the author Pankaj Parashar. The critic who praises the book unstintingly is Kamalanand Jha.

.....

Kunal

Thank you, Ashish Anchinhar.

It seems to have become a universal practice to make very serious allegations without naming the person concerned. To me this is hypocrisy at its worst. It is distasteful ...

Now the names have been given. It seems to me that Pankaj Parashar (novelist) and Kamalanand Jha (critic) should respond.

.....

Lakshman Jha Sagar

Such a thief ought to be socially ostracised. Fire and water should be denied to him. His face should be blackened and he should be paraded openly on a donkey. The punishment should be such that nobody dares commit so despicable an act again.

.....

Chitragupta Chitragupta

Extremely sad.

.....

Jagdanand Jha 'Manu'

Literary plagiarism in Mithila and Maithili is well known. But now, through the Sahitya Akademi and its writers ... a most reprehensible matter. Such people must certainly be exposed.

.....

Shridharam

As for Pankaj Parashar, I did not even think it necessary to read him. He has nothing but connections and manoeuvring in place of talent.

.....

Videha: The First Fortnightly Maithili E-Magazine, ISSN 2229-547X, VIDEHA (since 2004), http://videha.co.in/. A comment on the report in issues 26–50: "Pankaj Jha Parashar is a thief of long standing."

.....

kellner@ucla. edu"

Dear Gajendra, thanks for the detective work. was there a response? best regards,

Douglas Kellner, Philosophy of Education Chair

Social Sciences and Comparative Education, University of California-Los Angeles, Box 951521, 3022B Moore Hall, Los Angeles, CA 90095-1521, Fax 310 206 6293, Phone 310 825 0977
http://www.gseis.ucla.edu/faculty/kellner/kellner.html

.....

Dear Gajendra-ji, I received your email. I was deeply saddened to learn of Pankaj-ji's conduct. It will bring disrepute to Maithili. Your action is entirely appropriate. —Rajiv K. Verma

.....

These People are hellbent to bring down the literary discourse down to the gutter. Now you have been receiving mails like one. We are with you and i have forwarded your mails to Maithili speaking people all across the country. Sir I have sent the link of Parashar's duplicacy to several people along with Pranabh Bihari who had traslated that article. I had telephonic conversation with him also and he was quite upset over Parashar' s duplicay. Pranav is my junior and a good friend of mine. since you have referred Pranav who had traslated that article it is unfortunate that he was misused by Parashar. But i must congratulate you for exposing scam run by Parashar and his team. Parashar, though must not be blamed if he lifted the article of Nom Chomskey . Now i must doubt the artistic sensibility of Parashar who is now a pseudo-- intellectuals. I am amazed that how did he

dare to publish the article of Nom Chomskey as his own. God bless him no more. - VIJAY DEO JHA

.....

Thank you. But such people are honoured everywhere. —Shridharam

.....

I am sending this for your information (some reprehensible deeds of Pankaj Parashar). Pankaj has been doing such things for some time. —Avinash

.....

Dear Gajendra g, You are doing very well in the field of collecting all the documents related to the Maithili. Videha. Com realy a adventureous collection. I will also find some time to learm the article published through the videha. Now your detective style theft the sleeping of many of the so called literary personnel. Go a head. jai Maithili jai Mithila- Sunil Mallick, President, MINAP, Janakpur

.....

your efforts are commendable. Anysuch ghost writer or fake identity holder must be boycotted from literature at once Thanks.- shyamanand choudhary

.....

Greetings. I have delivered a copy of the email to the secretary of the Chetna Samiti. —Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman'

.....

Dear Gajendra-ji, I did not know that the Chetna Samiti had honoured him, although I too am a permanent member of Chetna. Be that as it may, this is a reprehensible episode, and it has distressed me. My own affectionate tendency to assess and encourage certain young Maithili talents has become a source of anxiety following this mishap. I myself am astonished. A very sad spectacle. In the literary context, this anti-creative act will be remembered as one of the ugliest episodes in modern Maithili. With affection, —Gangesh Gunjan

.....

Dear Maithils, remember your language, traditions and culture, and put an end to such controversial writing and conduct. Taking God as witness, place your hand on your heart, remember your family deity and ask yourselves how close you are to the truth. It would be best to use this forum for constructive work. Thank you. With affection, —P. K. Choudhary

.....

Gajendra Babu, Pankaj has been a thief for a long time. We condemned his actions in writing in Aarambh ten years ago. You have done well to ban him. The Chetna Samiti should withdraw its award and condemn him. — Subhash Chandra Yadav

.....

Dear Thakur-ji (honourable editor of the Maithili Videha e-magazine), on the evidence available so far, I would choose to stand with you. — Shambhu Kumar Singh

.....

Dear Gajendraji,

I fully agree with you that we must fight against blatant cases of wrongful appropriation.

Yes, you wrote in your email that all the writings of the author concerned would be removed from the Videha archive. That would also erase this episode and its evidence from the archive. In my view, evidence of both good and bad deeds ought to remain. Your comments and decision could be preserved as a postscript to the relevant writing in the archive for future readers. There is little point in repeating that Videha is making an excellent impression and that your hard work is clearly visible. Yours, — Sadan Jha

.....

Thank you.- Nishikant Thakur

.....

Thanx Gajendraji, for your immediate response. I must congratulate you for the work you have done to save the sanctity of the literature world as a whole. I feel proud for the person like you who shows the courrage to bell the cat. If the so called writers like Parasharji are there to spoil the sea, on the other side it is very hopeful sight to have a person like you who is alert enough to take care of such filth & keep the sea clean. Thanx for enlightening me on the subject. Regards- Bhalchandra Jha.

.....

This action of Pankaj Parashar brings to mind an incident some twenty or twenty-five years ago, when a poet broadcast the one poignant Maithili lyric by the late Sir Ganganath Jha over All India Radio, Darbhanga, claiming it as his own. Subsequently, after an alert listener provided the information, that poet was banned for life. The point is that if someone in

Darbhanga–Madhubani can claim Ganganath Babu's lyric as his own, this is hardly surprising. Stern action against such a writer is certainly necessary. —Ajit Mishra

.....

Dear Gajendrajee, We should take strong step to prevent such intellectual cheats. My support is always with you.- K N Jha

.....

This seems to be a dangerous trend and we should also try and refrain from publishing anything from such authors. Regards,- Prof. Udaya Narayana Singh

.....

Dear Thakur-ji, I am enormously delighted to learn that Maithili writers are now also committing cybercrime. To reward the full deployment of Pankaj Parashar's negative intellect, I should like him to receive an honour such as the Nobel Prize. —Buddhinath Mishra

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Honourable editor, thank you for your efforts to stop such misconduct. It is essential to protect Maithili from such blackmailers. Respectfully, — Shiv Kumar Jha

.....

Gajendra Bhai, greetings! This sort of thing has been happening continuously in Maithili. Some people are advancing this trade. A number of supposedly literary figures who read English are taking advantage of the ignorance of Maithili editors. I too read the article by Pankaj-ji in Pahal, and a few days later I also read the original author's article online. I was surprised that Pankaj-ji had not at least changed its title. But had he had that much knowledge, things would have been different. Not only this: many of his poems, too, have been altered from English literature. Well, let him do as he pleases ... This time, however, the proverb "A single stroke by the blacksmith is worth a hundred by the goldsmith" ought to prove true. Anyone committing such a wrong in publishing should be regarded as a serious offender. Thank you for raising the matter so forcefully. Yours, —Prakash Chandra (Prakash Jha, Mailorang)

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The Pankaj Parashar episode was very distressing. —Kamini

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Gajendra-ji, the more you magnify this affair, the more everyone's energy will be consumed by it. My view is simply that, since you have exposed the matter once, it should now be left alone. The same thing happens in Hindi. Repeated writings in harsh language distress me. I then wonder why we should waste our time on it. Caste will not disappear from India, and even less so from Maithili. I once refused to believe this, but after thirty years of writing in Maithili I have begun to see the following:
1. In Maithili literature, when people name women writers after Lili-ji, Usha-ji and Shefalika-ji, they mention me.
2. Whenever a periodical is launched, I am still asked to contribute.
3. I am as active as ever and continue to write regularly.
4. Sadly, after me—though I regard Sushmita Pathak and Jyotsna Milan as my contemporaries—no comparably strong woman writer has appeared.
5. Despite this, when I look around I find that almost nothing has been written about me, my literary journey or my work, whether by Mohan Bhardwaj or anyone else. When my decade is discussed, three or four names are treated at length, but mine is omitted. It is included only as a passing reference.
6. Over all these years, only Raman-ji has written an article about me. I shall have it retyped and send it to you.
7. I never paid attention to caste, religion or animosity. I now begin to wonder whether that is why I find myself in this situation.
8. A teacher of mine, himself a renowned Hindi storyteller, advised me to stop writing in Maithili. He said that because I was not of the particular caste regarded as Maithil, Maithils would never take notice of my writing or do anything for me. Out of love for my language I ignored his advice and went on writing. Now I wonder whether he was right.
9. Look at the situation in Maithili today, and do something about it. Large Maithili institutions such as the Chetna Samiti celebrate Vidyapati festivals every year, spending lakhs, but they never publish even five or seven books by good writers on those occasions.
10. I am told that Vidyapati Hall is rented out. I have no objection if it brings in income. Yet when the hall is sought for Maithili work or theatre, it is not made available. If the fee is paid, anyone can rent it. Such practices should be brought to light.
11. Institutions are larger than individuals. Write about all the institutions, including the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili department.
12. Lili-ji has granted me translation rights to all her works. For the past two or three years I have been writing to seek a Hindi translation project for her Sahitya Akademi Award-winning book Marichika. I have been published with translations in the Akademi's journal Samakalin Bharatiya Sahitya for twenty-five years. Yet I was asked to provide a translation sample. If the self-important person occupying that chair did not know about me, he could have asked another Maithili writer. It was like a

television channel asking Hrishikesh Mukherjee for his résumé, or, according to a recent news report, a request that Acharya Janaki Vallabh Shastri submit a biography for the Padma Shri.
13. In a spirit of humility, I sent Hindi translations of two or three of Lili-ji's stories. Even then, the matter received no consideration. After I wrote again, I was told to help obtain Lili-ji's translation rights for the Sahitya Akademi. But my concern was translation: if I am prepared to do the translation, why should the Akademi need the rights? So that it can give the work to its preferred person. No decision has yet been made, and no further letter has arrived from the Akademi. The translation is ready. Lili-ji is now very elderly. Her sole wish—and a natural one—is to see her books published in her lifetime.
14. It was I who helped bring Lili-ji's books into Hindi, yet Maithili critics see no need to record that fact, even if they acknowledge it. Fight against this.
15. I took the initiative to bring Maithili publishing to Bharatiya Jnanpith, and books by Prabhas-ji and Lili-ji appeared there. Though the credit for bringing Maithili books to Bharatiya Jnanpith belongs to me, Maithili critics see no need to record it. Fight against this as well.
Gajendra-ji, campaign against these attitudes in Maithili so that writers, including senior writers, need not suffer humiliation. If you wish, you may publish this in Videha. I shall write more on other matters. But I repeat that I blame not individuals so much as institutions and their mentality. Let people read this and ask these self-proclaimed eminent figures: why do you write about people with whom you are on good terms, but treat in this way someone with whom you have no such connections, who has continued to write quietly without entering controversies? —Vibha Rani

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Shri Gajendra-ji, good work. We shall continue to expect from you this discrimination between milk and water. After exposing a thief in this way, efforts should also be made to punish him. You have undertaken many commendable initiatives. Congratulations. —Manoj Pathak

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We should be greatful to Pankaj Parashar that he did not lay claim on the magnum opus of Kavi Vidyapati. I know him very well and his group as well. They have no love for Maithili in fact they are the moles planted by vested Hindi writers to damage maithili. Parashar and likes are the distructive lots and they are the culprits for agonising senior writers of Maithili those who dedicated their life for Maithili language and literature. I have no sympathy for him. I cant say, even, God bless them. - Chitra Mishra

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Taranand Viyogi (Mithila Srijan, June–July 2010, Year 1, No. 2): Some of his [Pankaj Parashar's] works were born after he had read the poetry of others. The poems are wholly his, yet some people have found occasion to call Pankaj a poet-thief. I find that, although he may be a critic who steals, he is certainly not a poet-thief. Why, then, did this happen? Because, as he absorbed others' writings into his own experience, their aura so overwhelmed him that its imprint became visible in the imagery of his poems. This is really a lack of artistic maturity, which a writer can overcome only by continuing to create.

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Gaurinath (Analkant), editorial in Antika, October–December 2009–January–March 2010, on the Pankaj Parashar affair: Yes, certain scheming people manage to find their way everywhere, and such people display their cunning and their art of theft here too. Yet it is no longer impossible to expose the truth about them. Gajendra Thakur of Videha recently revealed the true face of one such "young man" (Pankaj Jha, alias Pankaj Parashar).

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Pankaj Jha Parashar has allegedly been engaged in such activities before: publishing Harekrishna Jha's poems in Hindi without permission. The allegation is further supported, the editor says, by his publication of Vidyanand Jha's poem in a Hindi periodical without permission. (This information came from Harekrishna Jha. After it appeared in Videha, Pankaj Jha Parashar telephoned and harassed him while he was ill. Harekrishna Jha also informed me by telephone. I asked whether the information should be removed from Videha. He replied: "Leave it there; that is the truth." —Editor.) Parashar had done this several times, the editor continues, but on this occasion he published someone else's work under his own name, not even as a translation. —Editor

Ramesh

72. Debate: Pankaj Parashar's Literary Plagiarism Is a Dark Chapter in Maithili Literature

Abstract

With Videha–Sadeha 2 (2009–10), the vessel of sin associated with Pankaj Parashar's alleged literary plagiarism and cybercrime burst open. Great credit for this belongs to the periodical's editor, Shri Gajendra Thakur. No amount of praise can do justice to his alertness in detecting such offences.

Keywords: Pankaj Parashar; controversy over literary plagiarism; originality; translation; literary ethics; readers' responses; Videha–Sadeha

With Videha–Sadeha 2 (2009–10), the vessel of sin associated with Pankaj Parashar's alleged literary plagiarism and cybercrime burst open. Much credit for the exposure belongs to the magazine's editor, Shri Gajendra Thakur; his vigilance in detecting these alleged offences cannot be praised enough. Whether Videha's special issue on Maithili essays and criticism will remain bound, delayed across generations, "listening to time", for the sake of this exposure is difficult to predict.

Isolated instances of the art of literary theft have appeared before. But once an act of plagiarism was detected, the literary figure accused generally took a vow of silence, and the matter gradually cooled down.

Contrary to that tradition, however, this time the accused has proved to be an especially persistent thief, according to the essay, and has continued breaking in and stealing for the past decade. Yet Maithili writers and institutions have raised such a person in the palms of their hands, bestowed awards upon him, and soaked allegedly stolen poems in the syrup of favourable criticism.

Videha–Sadeha 2 did not merely advance allegations backed by evidence: it demonstrated its "boldness" by imposing a literary sanction on a person portrayed as ambitious and antisocial. Someone caught stealing three times in a decade may well be a "daredevil", using senior members of his own circle as rungs of a ladder to fulfil boundless and improper ambitions, only to kick the ladder away once his purposes are served. He then loses no time in descending to the lowest level of abuse on Twitter, Facebook, the Internet or in periodicals. He assumes changing names to hurl insults and busies JNU students with writing postcards praising him. He links his own name with the daughter of a distinguished Hindi writer, relishing and circulating tales of marriage or romance. Similar manoeuvring can be seen among others who chant the names of renowned Hindi writers in the hope of establishing their own literary establishments. Why, indeed, does

the younger generation of Maithili writers need the crutch of eminent Hindi names so badly? This is a genuinely troubling question.

Reading Videha's "report of the inquiry" makes one's hair stand on end. After the disclosures about this supposed writer in Pahal 86 and Aarambh 23, he ought, the essay argues, to have been excluded from Maithili literary life. Instead, the Chetna Samiti honoured him. Even the discerning institution Maithil Brahman Samaj at Rahika, Madhubani, seems to have been dazzled, although it includes the celebrated writer Uday Chandra Jha "Vinod" and learned professors. Vinod-ji must surely have had a significant role in recommending the award. Despite Videha's disclosure, neither the Chetna Samiti nor the Maithil Brahman Samaj of Rahika has felt obliged to withdraw its award or take any other action; both have maintained an icy silence. Do such "inert institutions" serve Maithili literature or harm it? How can we believe that not one office-bearer or literary member of either institution had read Pahal 86 or Aarambh 23?

It is astonishing that several major Maithili writers appear to have been captivated by Pankaj Parashar's contrived poetry and imported vocabulary. The preface to Vilambit Kaek Yug Me Nibaddh needlessly lists thirty or forty foreign writers. The essay suggests that only an audacious plagiarist would do this to certify his verse as world-class. As with Douglas Kellner, evidence may perhaps be found in this volume of borrowing from the conceptual worlds or vocabularies of those poets. Who can tell what Mr Hyde will do next? People in Maithili read relatively little world literature: why would a blackmailer not exploit that fact? What, after all, is "technopolitics"—merely technical politics, is it not? Such a device can be used to secure a trip even to Pakistan by deception, to obtain the Kiran–Yatri Award, the Vaidehi–Maheshwari Singh "Mahesh" Award, and even the Akademi Award associated with Vidit-ji. It can overstep the proprieties of the nephew–uncle relationship involving Pradeep Bihari's son; it can break into Professor Arun Kamal's Naye Ilaqe Mein and claim to have "listened to time". Above all, with the aid of this technical politics, a review of Vilambit Kaek Yug... can be obtained from a literary stalwart such as Jivakant, published in a journal like Mithila Darshan (5), and thereby used to establish one's name for posterity. "Technopolitics" is Maithili literature's most successful instrument!

One may accept that the editor of Mithila Darshan did not have access in Kolkata to Aarambh 23 and Pahal 86. But it is difficult to believe that Jivakant-ji had not read them. Surely he had read Prayag Shukla's Chandrabhaga Mein Suryodaya and Narayan-ji's Maithili poem of the same title, Chandrabhaga Me Suryodaya. Why, then, did Parashar's poem, which asks innumerable questions of the sea, fail to strike him as familiar? Why did he have to lavish praise on it in his review—or why was he made

to do so? Why should this not be considered a "sponsored review"? Did Jivakant find greater originality in Parashar's poem than in the poems on the sea by Prayag Shukla and Narayan-ji? Did the reviewer not even suspect the slightest "shadow" of those poems? A critic who noticed "all the heart-rending cries of civilisation" did not find literary theft uncivilised and grievously painful? The editor of Mithila Darshan probably never imagined that a critic like Jivakant-ji would find his "position false"; nor did Uday Chandra Jha "Vinod". Perhaps only Pankaj Parashar possessed that insight. The soul of the sage Parashara must be weeping in heaven, while all the lotuses born of mud confront an unbelievable reality. Three acts of theft committed by someone of the Parashara lineage must also have brought tears to the late Kiran-ji, the author of the epic Parashar.

Why did Jivakant-ji fail to take notice of literary plagiarism when, in his own view, "Maithili critics often drink stupidity and then vomit poison" (Videha–Sadeha 2, 2009–10; interview with Vinit Utpal)? Jivakant himself reviewed Parashar's collection of allegedly stolen poems and became an enthusiastic admirer of the poet whose skill in appropriation is questioned here. Why, then, should the excessive praise implicit in that review not feel like "poison-vomiting" to an attentive reader? If an "expert and habitual" literary plagiarist can manoeuvre a well-read critic like him into a "false position" and obtain both praise and prizes, is that a triumph of Maithili poetry or its misfortune?

Why was Videha–Sadeha alone in condemning this episode? Why did no other periodical do so? If Dr Ramanand Jha "Raman" denounced it on the Internet, why not in the periodical he himself edits? When the Chetna Samiti, Patna, honours such writers, how can it publish a condemnation in its own journal, especially when it has declined to withdraw the award even after the information was made available and concerned writers requested action? If Nachiketa-ji condemned the incident online and the condemnation appeared in Videha, why did neither condemnation nor information appear in Mithila Darshan? The reason, the essay argues, is plain: if a review of Parashar's poetry book by Jivakant is published, how can the journal also denounce poems allegedly plagiarised in that very book?

The ideals, decorum and ethics of literature are being torn to shreds on all sides, before the eyes of elders and teachers and, however unwittingly, through their own actions. What difference ultimately remains between the Maithil Brahman Samaj at Rahika, the Chetna Samiti at Patna, and the Sahitya Akademi in New Delhi? Why do the distinguished overseers and judges of such prestigious awards not feel it necessary to read the newer writers? How proper are their awards and critical judgements if they are

made without reading, when this is claimed to be the third instance of plagiarism and the alleged facts have been published and exposed? Why should the patronage extended by revered senior writers not be regarded as patronage of poetic and journalistic plagiarism, when Aarambh, Maithil Jan, Pahal and Videha–Sadeha had already published the material? Is encouraging literary theft not a form of encouraging an intermediary clique? Is it harmful or beneficial to Maithili literature to nurture a promising young poet whose originality has already been questioned three times? Are reviews written and prizes decided by examining a book's attractive cover or the list of foreign poets named in its preface? If this is so, then perhaps, as the ironic refrain goes, "Everything is just fine, brother!"

All this seems to confirm Jivakant-ji's observation that reviewers write their reviews after drinking liquor, money or stupidity. Douglas Kellner's "Technopolitics", the essay alleges, was published as stolen work in Pahal. Now Jivakant-ji, Gyan Ranjan-ji, and other Hindi writers and editors should be asked what became of the piece associated with Noam Chomsky: where did it go, what happened to it, and under whose name was it published—Pankaj Parashar's, or the name of Pradeep Bihari-ji's son, as a translation? If this research has not yet been done, might another literary theft be exposed in the future? How many ponds should a single fish be allowed to pollute, and how often? The practice of writing abuse under the name "Uday Kant" is an old one, according to the essay, for this "Dr Great Thief". He can call someone a "reptile" (in Maithil Jan) or enter a family's affairs and spew venom. "Dr Paul Baba", possessed of all the attributes of an octopus, is supposedly so gifted in predicting theft that famous football teams keep him in their employ, so that this "infallible weapon" may be used as required during the World Cup.

The title of his first story, read at the Saharsa story gathering, was Ham Pagal Nahi Chhi ("I Am Not Mad"). Why he needed to make such a declaration is now becoming clear. At the time Avinash and Pankaj Parashar's maternal uncle had declared the story, in their comments, a "turning point" in Maithili fiction. Today that "turning point" has indeed proved to be a turning point in a sense, because the word "not" seems to have disappeared from its title with his alleged third act of theft. When his first alleged plagiarism, of Arun Kamal's poem Naye Ilaqe Mein, was condemned in a resolution, all the Saharsa writers except the "maternal uncle" and Dr Mahendra signed it and sent it to Aarambh. Today those who refused to sign are forced to look furtively to the left and right. That is the consequence of double characters and double standards. Avinash is exposed, the writer argues, when he writes in Videha–Sadeha 2: "I shall not make this public." What is the need to convey information secretly? Fear

of damaging relations with Pankaj Parashar, or anxiety over some "technopolitics"?

Readers' messages in Videha–Sadeha 2 expose the positions of several literary figures. Rajiv Kumar Verma, Shridharam, Sunil Mallick, Shyamanand Choudhary, Gangesh Gunjan, P. K. Choudhary, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Shambhu Kumar Singh, Vijaydev Jha, Bhalchandra Jha, Ajit Mishra, K. N. Jha, Prof. Nachiketa, Buddhinath Mishra, Shiv Kumar Jha, Prakash Chandra Jha, Kamini, Manoj Pathak and others forthrightly condemned the matter in strong language, whereas the veiled and guarded words of Avinash, Dr Ramanand Jha "Raman" and Vibha Rani arouse surprise. It is reassuring, however, that the readers' forceful expressions of feeling are not troubled by the muffled voices of writers.

Vibha Rani, for her part, has produced an extraordinary response. This was not the place to enumerate a hundred problems confronting Maithili language and literature. It is like doing one thing at the wrong time—ploughing at the time for harvesting and singing wedding songs during Shiva's marriage. Someone repeatedly reveals his misconduct, and she regards exposing him as a waste of time, even finding the exposure distressing. The degree of self-praise and inferiority expressed in her response can be appreciated if she rereads her own letter calmly. Because the same thing happens in Hindi, should it be excused in Maithili? Must every action in Maithili now be taken only after seeking Hindi's permission? How can Vibha Rani call Jyotsna Chandram "Jyotsna Milan"? How can she claim to have been neglected? She is invited to literary programmes, receives honours and awards, and is read and discussed by readers. Do upper-caste writers, too, not complain about the absence of criticism in Maithili? The condition of reviewing and criticism is equally difficult for writers of every caste. If there is a caste distinction here, it is that Brahmin critics, from the perspective of reservation, have reviewed somewhat more writing by authors of supposedly lower castes, and generally favourably.

If a writer succumbs to despair because of the uneven state of literary criticism, what becomes of commitment to writing? Vibha-ji seems unaware that, after the writers she names, women such as Kamini, Nutan Chandra Jha, Vandana Jha and Mala Jha have entered Maithili literature with their own distinctive force. She has read neither Kamini's poetry collection nor Ijoriyak Angaithi Mor. Who ever stopped her from following her teacher's advice and writing in Hindi? Indeed, she has written in Hindi. The impulse of the mother tongue is unique. I have no objection to striking at Maithili's inert institutions and reviewers, though the monetary rewards here are negligible. Vibha-ji has certainly received

social recognition. Society contains conscious as well as inert people. Maithili literature and the society of Mithila expect much from her; she needs to rise above inferiority and self-glorification and work. She is capable of it. She should avoid the race for credit. Otherwise, what distinction will remain between a Sahitya Akademi representative, a bankrupt jury, and a capable Maithili writer? The direction in which Vibha Rani is drifting worries and pains me. She is a powerful writer who has produced strong work. Sooner or later reviewers will be compelled to take up their pens. Why should any writer lose heart because critics have neglected their duty?

There is nothing improper in a writer responding meaningfully to allegations of repeated literary plagiarism by Pankaj Parashar. A commitment to literary values ought to be central to the writer's vocation, along with the "boldness" needed to show it in public. Literature contains an abundance of declarations about what "ought" to be done. Silence in literature and society on grave matters of this kind encourages such acts, deepens an oppressive inertia and brings disrepute upon language and letters. So long as reviews are being written of Parashar's allegedly plagiarised poetry, who will review Vibha Rani's original writing? Who will consider it necessary? Surely Vibha Rani will not commission reviews of herself. A capable writer's conduct has standards of its own. Literary theft should therefore be condemned collectively.

Some readers' views on Ramesh's essay, "Debate: Pankaj Parashar's Literary Plagiarism Is a Dark Chapter in Maithili Literature":

SHIV KUMAR JHA TILLOO, JAMSHEDPUR, said …

Thanks to Ramesh-ji. It is good to see the courage to speak the truth emerging in Mithila. People can do anything for sham popularity. I no longer even feel inclined to discuss Pankaj Parashar; however much he is condemned, it will be too little. But, Ramesh Babu, while you all condemn him, some people say "May Pankaj-ji live for ages." I too wish him a long life, but the wish for long life should not be reserved for Pankaj Parashar alone: "May all be happy." Ramesh Babu, may your pen keep moving without interruption.

Rama Jha said …

A woman who is my friend received from this man, Pankaj Parashar, a message so disgusting that I cannot reproduce it here. Publishing one's own work in another language while calling it an original is not necessarily theft, but it should be identified as translated by the author, whether from the Maithili original into another language such as Hindi or from another language such as Hindi into Maithili.

Ashish Anchinhar said …

As for the Parashar affair, no amount of condemnation is sufficient. But Ramesh Bhai, in which language should Vibha Rani be reviewed—in Hindi or in Maithili? In my view, to publish the same work in two or three languages, each time claiming it is an original, is also plagiarism. Attention should be paid to that as well.

Language, Dictionaries, Translation and Digital Culture

73. Cybercrime and How to Detect It

Abstract

Those engaged in intrigue in Maithili have begun entering the Internet. Previously they resorted to blackmail through letters and SMS messages. Now even someone with elementary computer knowledge can use email, and the tendency has increased …

Keywords: Internet; crime; detection; methods; criticism; Maithili

People engaged in intrigue within Maithili circles have begun to enter the Internet. Previously they practised blackmail by letter and SMS. Now that even people with elementary computer knowledge can use email, this tendency has increased.

Abstract · Summary

This chapter presents a language-and-technology study of "Cybercrime and How to Detect It". Its central concerns are the Internet, crime, detection and methods. Drawing on the examples, quotations and arguments available in the original material, it examines digital media, language technology, publishing and communication, allowing the reader to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its broader context.

Types of Internet Crime

Abusive and discouraging emails: Under altered names, people send emails and post comments, causing their targets mental distress. Sometimes the victim leaves the Internet, and everyday creative work suffers. Some even bid farewell to Maithili. Someone may place links to pornographic websites on your blog or site; another may flee after posting abuse in email, online conversation or a comment box. Someone else may copy and paste the labour of months or years in a few seconds and publish it under their own name. Many people have also reproached me for making years of my work freely available online. Yet I recall a statement by Bill Gates. Asked whether Microsoft had delayed introducing its Xbox product in India for fear of piracy, he said that Microsoft had never postponed a product's market launch for that reason. The Videha archive is becoming richer every day; cybercrime has not diminished that growth.

Threatening emails: A blackmailer uses these messages to intimidate the victim. Because the sender's identity is concealed, the recipient begins suspecting all kinds of people. The blackmailer derives satisfaction from displaying a fragmented personality.

Emails spreading viruses: A link or attachment arrives in an email, and before you have even knowingly clicked or opened it, the computer seems to have stopped working. Messages of this sort may also reach a mobile phone when Bluetooth is switched on.

Fake mail: A message from one source is disguised so that it appears to have been sent from another person's email address. A blackmailer thereby tries to provoke a quarrel between you and someone else. Do not delete such mail, and do not reply to it either.

The next stage—financial loss: The interruption of creative activity may not cause immediate financial loss, but at the next stage a blackmailer may ask for your credit-card number, password or bank-account number. The email may appear to concern an income-tax refund or to convey the moving appeal of a famine victim in Sudan. Never answer such messages; place the email in the spam folder, and keep copies as evidence. The ordinary procedure for detecting the offender is described in the next point.

How to detect the offender: Install a hit counter on your website so that visits acquire timestamps. Compare these with the timestamps of comments to help identify the culprit. Use computer commands to inspect the full email header and obtain information about time and place. The alleged sender's address and telephone number, including an extension, may sometimes be inferred from this information. Do not destroy or alter any such email.

Controlling possible harm from Internet use: Such emails create difficulties for users. People become upset; some even cancel their Internet connections. But when an abusive message arrives, remain in control of yourself and do not fall into depression. Continue using the constructive side of the Internet. If you have logged in to a website, log out promptly.

74. The Information Society, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the Indian Constitution

Abstract

An information society is one in which the creation, distribution, circulation, use, integration and modification of information are important economic, political and cultural activities. Those able to participate in this society are called digital citizens. In this post-industrial society, information technology shapes production, the economy and social life.

Keywords: information society; universal; human rights; declaration; Indian Constitution; criticism

An information society is a society in which the creation, distribution, dissemination, use, integration and modification of information constitute important economic, political and cultural activities. Those capable of participating in it are called digital citizens. In such a post-industrial society, information technology determines production, economic organisation and social life. The concept is closely related to postmodern society and post-industrial society. The economist Fritz Machlup formulated an account of the knowledge industry based on five components: education; research and development; media; information technology; and information services. The effect of technology and information on society becomes evident here. This is the society in which we now live.

Abstract · Summary

This chapter presents dramatic criticism on "The Information Society, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights and the Indian Constitution". Its central concerns are the information society, universality, human rights and the Declaration. On the basis of examples, quotations and arguments in the original material, it examines dramatic texts, character arrangement, stage structure and cultural context, enabling readers to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its larger setting.

Following the two world wars and the challenge of fascism, the United Nations General Assembly proclaimed and adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights on 10 December 1948. It laid down common standards for all peoples and nations without discrimination on political, economic, cultural or religious grounds.

The first United Nations World Summit on the Information Society was held in two phases: at Geneva, Switzerland, from 10 to 12 December 2003,

and at Tunis, Tunisia, from 16 to 18 November 2005. The relationship between human rights and information technology was recognised there.

The following provisions of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights bear upon the information society. (Maithili translation of the Declaration by Dr Ramanand Jha "Raman".)

Article 12

No person shall be subjected to arbitrary interference with their privacy, family, home or correspondence, nor to attacks upon their honour and reputation. Everyone has the right to legal protection against such interference or attacks.

Article 18

Everyone has the right to freedom of thought, conscience and religion. This includes the freedom to change one's religion or belief and, alone or in community with others, publicly or privately, to manifest that religion or belief through teaching, practice, worship and observance.

Article 19

Everyone has the right to freedom of opinion and expression, including freedom to hold opinions without interference and to seek, receive and impart information and ideas through any medium and regardless of frontiers.

Article 27

1. Everyone has the right freely to participate in the cultural life of the community, to enjoy the arts,

and to share in scientific advancement and its benefits.

2. Everyone has the right to the protection of the moral and material interests arising from any scientific, literary or artistic work

of which that person is the creator.

Article 21
1. Everyone has the right to take part in the government of their country, directly or through freely chosen representatives.
2. Everyone has the right to equal access to public service in their country.
3. The will of the people shall be the basis of governmental authority. That will shall be expressed in periodic and genuine elections held by universal and equal suffrage, by secret vote or an equivalent free voting procedure.

The digital divide reveals divisions of knowledge, society and economy. It demonstrates the need to construct a nondiscriminatory information

society in which developing countries retain sovereign rights in relation to information technology.

The relationship between human rights and information technology also embraces the individual's right to privacy. Scholars, human-rights activists and others have begun debating whether the information society will strengthen or damage human rights in matters of freedom of expression, the right to information, privacy, freedom from discrimination, gender equality, intellectual property, political participation, association, and information and communication technologies.

The right to confidentiality in online correspondence, cultural and linguistic diversity in Internet content, and media education are also implicated. The technical instruments of the information society benefit from its rights and freedoms, and participate in society's comprehensive development and in the definition of universal rights and freedoms, their mutual differences, and the values attached to them.

This creates conditions for easier access to information, knowledge and culture, turning the user into an actor in the global information society. Users gain greater freedom of expression than before and the capacity to produce new content and new social networks. There is consequently a felt need for new legal, economic and social models based on shared responsibilities, knowledge and understanding. Children's interests constitute another concern and should always take precedence over those of adults.

The tendency to accumulate economic, social and cultural wealth in modern society has intensified in the information society, while technology has brought about a kind of structural unemployment.

Poverty, workers' rights and the ideal of the welfare state are being left behind amid calculations of profit and loss. Today only a few actors are wanted; publishers, too, promote only the authors of a few best-selling books. The same is visible in theatre, painting, cinema and other fields. Information is not invariably beneficial. It encompasses not only art and books but also the stock market and commissioned survey reports. It reduces the distance between time and place and establishes a certain balance between them.

The notion of human dignity shifts emphasis away from a person's birth-based social position and towards the right to dignity. Emancipatory movements, including women's liberation, are efforts in that direction.

Free use of information remains restricted, while people's privacy is disappearing. When Bill Gates was asked during a visit to India whether Microsoft had delayed launching the Xbox there because of piracy, he

reportedly answered that Microsoft had never delayed a product out of fear of piracy. Fear of spam and piracy should be overcome.

The information society is the society in which we live. Democracy and respect for human rights must continue in the information society and the society that follows it. Freedom of expression, the right to privacy, the right to share information and the right of access to information—all connected with the circulation of information—face threats from the state and from the market-oriented tendencies of the information society.

The Internet is the people's medium: a system that enables dialogue among people. It breaks down the strongholds of the entrenched gatekeepers of mass communication.

The Internet does not usually have editors. Individuals create their own topics and content and communicate them themselves. This initiates many social conversations; nevertheless, a great deal of antisocial content also appears. Should it be banned? If software is given the authority to make machines prohibit content, it will be a serious blow to freedom of expression.

Intellectual-property rights, the text observes, protect publication and distribution for sixty years after an author's death. Piracy must also be prohibited on the Internet, and arrangements should preserve authors' rights in their material for at least twenty years after death. Yet excessive use of patents will obstruct developing countries' access to information and hinder technological development.

Copyright can also encourage cultural development in music, film and comics. In a digital environment one cannot even view Internet content without making a copy, so there is only a limited difference between offline and online copyright. Online copyright also restricts copying, although it is extremely easy to incorporate copied material into other objects or modify it. Therefore names and images should not be used without their creators' permission; other people's private conversations and chats should not be interfered with; and statements that falsely prejudice the public against another person should not be made. Similarly, when an employer uses electronic devices to monitor employees, that monitoring ought to conform to International Labour Organization guidelines. Unsolicited email messages and the unauthorised collection or use of medical reports also violate human rights.

Internet use nevertheless remains restricted, because much content and software is expensive and unavailable free of charge. The digital divide makes inequalities in education still more conspicuous. Because mental rather than physical labour plays a larger role here, one might hope that

gender inequality would diminish in the information society. Surveys, however, show that women have less access to information technology.

Electronic libraries, Braille-enabled or audio-enabled computer screens, and other electronic-library resources can help people with disabilities, including blind people, undertake e-commerce from home. Yet the research and its resulting technologies remain so costly that their benefits have not been as great as they might have been.

Children, older people, people with disabilities, women, workers, migrant workers and other socially disadvantaged groups continue to experience disadvantage in the information society.

The right to share in scientific progress and its benefits also entitles each person to protection of the moral and material interests arising from scientific, literary or artistic works of their own creation. Accordingly, in an information society respectful of human rights, the production of content through information and broadcasting technology, and the regulation of copyright and intellectual property, should be arranged so that the provisions of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights are honoured, not disregarded.

Article 27 [Article 51(a) of the Indian Constitution, as cited in the original]

75. Indian Dalit Literature: Maithili Translation, Criticism and Aesthetics

Abstract

Poetry • Fiction • Translation • Critical Theory • Rasa Perspective • Parallel Literary Tradition. Boyi Bhimanna (1920–2001) was a pillar of Telugu Dalit literature. His poetry is not simply an expression of individual suffering; it is also a record of collective historical consciousness.

Keywords: Indian · Dalit · Translation · Aesthetics · Literary Criticism · Maithili

Abstract

This chapter examines "Indian Dalit Literature: Maithili Translation, Criticism and Aesthetics". Poetry • Fiction • Translation • Critical Theory • Rasa Perspective • Parallel Literary Tradition. Boyi Bhimanna (1920–2001) was a pillar of Telugu Dalit literature. His poetry is not merely an expression of personal pain but a record of collective historical consciousness. The two poems under discussion—Gudiselu Kalipotunnayi and Na Varasatvapu Hakkulu—represent distinct yet connected aspects of his poetic world: the vicious circle of religious violence and a rereading of mythological history. Their most striking formal feature is their question-and-answer structure. The poem repeatedly asks itself: "Whose hut is this?

Poetry • Fiction • Translation • Critical Theory • Rasa Perspective • Parallel Literary Tradition

Consolidated edition — All criticism, theoretical discussions, literary texts and appendices collected in the original document are presented in a single editorial sequence. Repeated material has been consolidated only where repetition was verified; the original meaning and material have been preserved.

Subject Guide
1. Telugu Dalit poetry and Dalit women's poetry
2. Gujarati and Odia Dalit poetry
3. Telugu Dalit short fiction and novels
4. Integrated criticism of translation and rasa theory
5. A theory of criticism for original and translated Dalit literature in Maithili
6. Vidyapati, Bidesiya and appendices on the parallel literary tradition
7. Bibliography

Criticism of Dalit Poetry: Two Poems by Boyi Bhimanna

Burning Huts and My Hereditary Rights

Preliminary Observations

Boyi Bhimanna (1920–2001) was a pillar of Telugu Dalit literature. His poetry is not merely an expression of personal pain but a document of collective historical consciousness. The two poems considered here—Gudiselu Kalipotunnayi and Na Varasatvapu Hakkulu—present two different yet

interconnected dimensions of his poetic world: on the one hand, the vicious circle of religious violence; on the other, a rereading of mythological history.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

Burning Huts

The poem's most striking formal feature is its question-and-answer structure. It repeatedly asks itself questions—"Whose huts are these?" and "Where do they keep springing up from?"—and then answers them; yet each answer becomes another question. This structure recalls the Socratic method, in which a sequence of questions uncovers truth. Here, however, truth lies not in a philosophical conclusion but in a bitter social reality.

Repetition—"are burning", "keep springing up"—creates an incantatory effect. Anaphora, the repetition of a word at the beginning of successive lines, and epistrophe, repetition at the ends of lines, bring the poem close to oral traditions and folk song. This suggests that Bhimanna embeds Dalit oral-cultural traditions within written poetry.

My Hereditary Rights

The structure of this poem is more fragmented and narrative. It leaps from one mythological episode to another—Vashishtha, Arundhati, Matsyagandhi, Vyasa—as though a troubled reader of history were hurriedly turning its pages. This fragmentation is no accident: it represents a Dalit consciousness of history in which memory has not remained whole but has been stolen and scattered.

The final lines move like long, laboured breaths—"Only to cast it away with pride! / Only to breathe with full dignity!" The ending is a declaration of victory, but not a moment of exuberant triumph; it conveys instead a solemn and profound experience of liberation.

2. Language and Metaphor

The Metaphor of the Hut

The central image of Burning Huts—the hut that burns and repeatedly rises again—is exceptionally layered. At one level it clearly evokes caste violence: the history of collective attacks on Dalits, of their dwellings being destroyed and set ablaze. At another, it makes ironic use of the Hindu philosophy of rebirth. The poet asks: if the doctrine of rebirth is true, why must this same Dalit be burned again and again? Rebirth was supposed to be a path towards liberation; for Dalits it becomes an endless vicious circle.

This accords with the analysis in Frantz Fanon's The Wretched of the Earth, a philosophical work of anti-colonial revolution, which shows how colonial and racial systems ensnare the oppressed in cycles of violence until the victims themselves begin to regard the cycle as normal—until "the inhabitants of these huts discover their secret."

The Metaphor of Digging Up the Graveyard

In My Hereditary Rights, the image of digging up a graveyard is extraordinarily complex. Ordinarily, such an act is associated with death and ill omen. Here the poet reverses its meaning: digging becomes an act of recovery. To excavate what was buried—the Vedic identity and historical rights of Dalits—and bring it to the surface becomes a revolutionary undertaking.

One hears here an echo of Walter Benjamin's "Theses on the Philosophy of History", the philosophical essay that demands a view of history from the perspective of the oppressed rather than the victors. Benjamin argues that history is customarily written from the victors' standpoint, and that the revolutionary task is to revive "dangerous memory". Bhimanna does precisely this: he excavates the dangerous memory buried by Brahmanical historiography.

3. A Counter-Mythological Reading

My Hereditary Rights belongs to an important tradition in Dalit literature: reading mythological narratives against the grain. B. R. Ambedkar established this mode of inquiry in Riddles in Hinduism and Who Were the Shudras? Bhimanna similarly puts the entire Mahabharata–Ramayana–Vedic tradition under interrogation.

The poem's central argument is that great figures of the Vedic-Aryan tradition—Vashishtha, Matsyagandhi and Vyasa—were in fact of casteless or Dalit origin. Brahmanical history, however, turned them into "Aryans", while excluding their actual descendants, the Dalits. The poem thus exposes a historical irony.

The perspective of Subaltern Studies, a scholarly tradition that places marginalised people's histories and voices at the centre, is relevant here. In "Can the Subaltern Speak?", Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak asks whether a Dalit woman can appear in history through her own voice. Bhimanna's poem offers an answer: it makes the subaltern speak. It gives Matsyagandhi, Amba and Ambalika—women who functioned merely as objects in the Mahabharata—a capacity for self-determination: "If she had slapped him and broken his teeth …" Such counterfactual imagination, the rereading of history by asking what might have happened had events taken another course, restores subaltern agency.

4. The Dalit-Woman Dimension

Both poems, and especially My Hereditary Rights, clearly articulate an intersectional Dalit-feminist perspective, analysing the simultaneous oppression of caste and gender. Arundhati, Matsyagandhi, Amba and Ambalika are women subjected to caste-based and gender-based exploitation together. The poem presents them not only as victims but as possible rebels.

Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersectionality, which explains how the oppressions of caste, gender and class operate together rather than separately,

is directly applicable here. That Bhimanna, a Dalit male poet, writes from this intersectional standpoint attests to the breadth of his poetic vision.

5. Dalit Aesthetics

Critics of Dalit literature, including Sharankumar Limbale, in Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature, and Omprakash Valmiki, have repeatedly emphasised that Dalit literature cannot be measured exclusively by the standards of Western poetics. In Dalit poetry:

Anger is an aesthetic category, not a fault. Political directness is not an artistic weakness but an ethical necessity. Individual and collective experience become inseparable: the "I" invariably stands for a social "we".

Both of Bhimanna's poems exemplify this aesthetic. The anger in Burning Huts is not empty rhetorical display; it is an authentic moral emotion. The erudition of My Hereditary Rights—its mythological references and historical consciousness—is not a mere exhibition of learning but a cultural project of self-respect.

6. The Challenges of Translation

The Maithili versions of these poems, themselves made from English translations, involve a double process of translation: Telugu → English → Maithili. Some poetic loss is inevitable. For example:

The Telugu word gudiselu, rendered in the discussion as "huts/homes", carries a doubleness, the sense of a home being set alight. The Maithili term khopṛī, as used in the source's discussion, is said to retain much of that ambiguity.

Yet some of the emotional intensity of Na Varasatvapu Hakkulu—in which equal stress falls upon "my" (na) and "rights" (hakkulu)—is attenuated in the Maithili title Hamar Paitṛk Adhikār ("My Hereditary Rights").

Even within the limits of this double translation, the poems' essential poetic force has entered Maithili. The power of Bhimanna's thought cannot be diminished by the linguistic medium through which it travels.

Conclusion

These two poems by Boyi Bhimanna stand at a level of Dalit literature where poetic technique and political philosophy become one. Burning Huts presents the cyclical character of religious violence as an enigmatic question; My Hereditary Rights rereads history against the grain and declares the restoration of Dalit identity.

Taken together, the poems formulate an entire Dalit philosophy: question, remember, reclaim and ultimately breathe freely, with pride. They are not simply poems but documents of a struggle between civilisational orders.

Criticism of Dalit Women's Poetry: Four Poems by J. Subhadra

Gleaning, Landa, The Edge of a Sari, and Avva

Preliminary Observations

J. Subhadra has a distinctive voice in Telugu Dalit women's poetry. Whereas Boyi Bhimanna rereads Dalit identity through the historical and mythological dimensions of experience, Subhadra brings the body, labour and household objects—hide, earthen pots and the edge of a sari—to the centre of poetry. Taken together, her four poems offer a comprehensive picture of Dalit women's lives: from field to home, labour to motherhood, hunger to dignity.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

Gleaning

The poem takes the form of an inventory of labour. Tasks follow one another from dawn to night—sweeping, plastering the floor, carrying water, clearing away dung—without pause or connective transition. This catalogue is no accident: it represents the breathless continuity of a Dalit woman's life. Walt Whitman also makes use of catalogues of labour in Song of Myself, but there the list signifies freedom; here it signifies bondage.

The final question—"How will this bonded life ever end?"—gathers the weight of the entire poem into a single slender thread. It is not a rhetorical question but a real question that has received no answer.

Landa

The structure of this poem is a process narrative: it follows the entire work of soaking, cleaning and softening hides. Such technical precision is unusual in poetry. The pulp of the golden-shower tree and tamarind seeds record forms of indigenous knowledge that Subhadra incorporates into the poem. In this sense, the poem is also an ethnographic document.

At the end—"To make creaking shoes and drums— / On those drums they beat out sweet rhythms"—lies a bitter irony. The hide that a woman processes under repellent conditions becomes the drum on which her husband plays "sweet rhythms". Subhadra reveals the unequal relationship between labour and art, suffering and beauty.

The Edge of a Sari

This is the longest and most complex of the four poems. Its structure rests on an extended metaphor: the edge of a sari is a single object continually taking on new forms—a bed, an umbrella, a bag, a cushion, a protector, a mother. This succession of transformations reflects the many roles of a Dalit woman, who is simultaneously a worker, mother, wife, beggar and resilient fighter.

The closing lines—"This is not a cloth standing guard over my breast"—negate the title itself. This is a performative contradiction: what the title asserts, the poem denies. The result is a dialectical tension. In what sense is the sari's edge not a guardian? The poet leaves that question open.

Avva

This poem has the most lyrical and elegiac structure of the four. The repeated word "Avva", Telugu for "mother", becomes an invocation, as though a goddess were being summoned during a ritual. But this is a goddess of domestic labour, not a goddess seated upon a golden throne.

Its succession of images is remarkably dense: the sun lost in the carpet of the sky, grains of rice in an empty storeroom, the beat of a torn drum. These are all metaphors of deprivation and displacement.

2. The Central Metaphor: A Poetics of Objects

Subhadra's most important poetic achievement is to make ordinary objects the centres of poems: the landa (a vessel used in processing hides), the water pot, the sari's edge, the hoe and the sickle.

Western poetics has a distinguished tradition of the object poem; Rainer Maria Rilke's New Poems provides outstanding examples. Rilke's objects, however, are aesthetic objects—an image of Apollo, a panther. Subhadra's are objects of labour, things associated with what society calls repellent, foul-smelling, dirty and degrading work.

A new Dalit poetics of objects emerges here: to render the labour, knowledge and identity of Dalit women visible through material things. What society refuses to see—the curing of hides or the gleaning of grains from the earth—the poet places at the centre of literature.

3. Body Politics and Material Reality

An extraordinary passage in Landa declares: "Even if my intestines come out through my mouth, / Even if I faint from the insects and the stench, / I must endure this fate of curing hides!"

This immediate realism of the body's interior—the naming of internal organs, reactions to smell and physical fainting—is characteristic of a tendency in Dalit literature that Gopal Guru terms "intense embodied experience". In upper-caste literature, the body is generally idealised or abstracted. In Dalit literature, the body is tangible, suffering and at work, without apologetic sanitisation.

The body appears differently in The Edge of a Sari: sweat, tears and menstrual blood are bodily fluids that a Brahmanical system of purity and pollution labels "impure". Subhadra accepts them without embarrassment within poetry, thus refuting the myth of purity.

Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection is pertinent here. According to Kristeva, society regards as abject those substances that cross the body's boundaries: blood, excrement and decay. By making these abjected substances the subject of her poetry, Subhadra rejects social abjection itself.

4. Intersecting Oppressions: Caste, Gender and Class

In all four poems caste, gender and class appear together, and their interaction is never separable.

In Gleaning: the necessity of working in a landlord's house (class and caste), being "beaten with a rough implement" (caste violence), and the placing of this entire burden upon a woman (gender).

In Avva: "she is scorched in the furnace of her father's anger" (domestic violence and gender), while "moneylenders and landlords have kept her away from the plough" (caste and class). Both forms of oppression operate within the same woman's life.

Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersectionality is given almost literal embodiment here. The Dalit woman represents neither Dalits alone nor women alone; hers is a third position, with experiences distinct from, and more complex than, either category taken separately.

In this connection, Sharmila Rege advances the idea of a "Dalit feminist standpoint": the Dalit woman's perspective carries a particular epistemological privilege because she experiences oppression at its deepest intersections. Subhadra's poems are written from that standpoint.

5. Motherhood and Deprivation: A Special Reading of Avva

Avva offers an extraordinary rereading of the poetry of motherhood. In Hindi and Sanskrit literature, the mother usually signifies sacrifice, gentleness and nurture—Yashoda and Kaushalya are familiar exemplars. Subhadra's Avva is fundamentally different.

She is a mother who cannot sing lullabies because she is at work; a mother whose hands are hard and soiled because she is always in the fields; a mother who cannot lull a child to sleep in her lap because she is bonded to a landlord.

This echoes Adrienne Rich's Of Woman Born, which examines motherhood at two levels: institution and experience. For Subhadra's Avva, institutional motherhood—the expectation of love and affection—and lived motherhood —the work of survival and feeding—exist together, but the former is always subordinate to the latter. Survival comes before tenderness: this is the Dalit mother's tragedy.

6. Folk Aesthetics and Indigenous Knowledge

The particular uses of golden-shower pulp and tamarind in Landa, the reference to Maisamma Devi in The Edge of a Sari, and the songs of transplanting, separation and threshing in Avva constitute a poetic archive of Dalit folk traditions.

In After Amnesia, Ganesh Devy argues that Indian literary criticism has consistently placed the sanctioned traditions of Sanskrit, Urdu and English at its centre while treating Dalit and Adivasi oral traditions as "non-literary". Subhadra's poems reject this exclusion. They elevate Dalit folk knowledge, oral traditions and regional botanical knowledge to the highest ground of poetry.

7. The Edge of a Sari and the Question of Jayaprabha

An important footnote at the end of the poem refers to the Telugu feminist poet Jayaprabha's "Burn the Edge of the Sari". Jayaprabha treats the sari's edge as a symbol of patriarchy and calls for it to be burned.

Subhadra clearly disagrees with this upper-caste feminist perspective. For her Avva, the sari's edge is neither a patriarchal emblem nor an enemy of freedom. It is an instrument of survival—a bed, shelter, bag and mother. To burn it would be to destroy the one possession she has.

This dialogue within feminism is profoundly important. In Sister Outsider, Audre Lorde writes: "The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house." Here, however, the issue becomes: which feminism, and whose feminism? From a Dalit woman's standpoint, upper-caste feminist symbolism can be blind to class and caste. Subhadra challenges that blindness firmly, though without rhetorical aggression.

8. Language and the Context of Maithili Translation

These poems have travelled through three linguistic stages: Telugu → English → Maithili. Some crucial cultural contexts have survived that journey:

"Landa" has been kept as a Telugu word, an appropriate decision. Translating it into Maithili would have been difficult and could have diminished the force of the original technical and cultural term.

"Avva" has been retained rather than replaced with the Maithili word for "mother", thereby preserving its Telugu cultural specificity.

Yet the Telugu title "Kongu Na Boche Meeda Kavalunde Bontapeggadu" (The Edge of a Sari) loses some of its bodily immediacy in Maithili. In Telugu, boche (breast/chest) and kavalunde (keeping watch) carry a bodily and political tension that becomes relatively literal in the Maithili expression "the cloth standing guard over the breast".

Conclusion

Taken together, J. Subhadra's four poems create an epic of Dalit women's lives —fragmented yet whole. From labour to motherhood, from body to history, from the edge of a sari to the struggles of an entire civilisation.

Their poetic achievement lies in the fact that they do not merely complain: they bear witness. Simone Weil considered the distinction between justice and compassion significant. Complaint comes from the sufferer; testimony comes from the witness. Subhadra becomes the witness to her own life, and her poetry consequently ceases to be merely a private cry of anguish and becomes a historical document.

The final line—"They never reached the limits of the places through which my Avva wandered"—is an epitaph for the entire collection: language, history and civilisation together have failed to map the whole geography of a Dalit woman's life.

Criticism of Dalit Women's Poetry (Continued): Comparative and Synthetic Study

9. The Two Poets Together: A Poetic Dialogue between Bhimanna and Subhadra

When the two parts of this critical study—Bhimanna's five poems and Subhadra's four—are read together, a dialectical dialogue emerges, revealing the complexity within Dalit literature itself.

A Difference of Perspective

Bhimanna looks from above: history, myth, philosophy, the long pressure of civilisation. His poetic camera adopts a wide-angle view. Subhadra looks from within: the body, objects, labour, home and mother. Hers is a close-up perspective.

Bhimanna's My Hereditary Rights excavates the histories of Vyasa and Vashishtha: a macro-history. Subhadra's Avva depicts one day in the labouring life of an unnamed mother: a micro-history. Yet these are two aspects of the same truth—historical dispossession and everyday exploitation, two sides of one coin.

Together, their collections bridge Carlo Ginzburg's microhistory and Marxist macrohistory, connecting the minute particulars of individual life to the epic of social structures.

The Difference between Questioning and Testimony

Bhimanna asks: "How do these huts keep springing up again and again?" and "How long will this vicious circle continue?" His mode is interrogative.

Subhadra testifies: "When my husband applies lime to the hide with his own hands"; "I do not remember ever clinging tightly to Avva's waist." Her poetic mode is evidentiary.

In Western literary theory, testimony became a distinct mode particularly through literature of the Holocaust—Elie Wiesel and Primo Levi. In Testimony: Crises of Witnessing, Shoshana Felman and Dori Laub show that testimony is not merely factual reporting; it is an ethical act in which the sufferer transforms experience into witness. In this sense, every poem by Subhadra constitutes testimony.

10. Images of Nature in Dalit Poetry: A Rereading

In upper-caste Hindi and Sanskrit poetry, nature generally provides a domain of aesthetic experience: in Kalidasa's Meghaduta, it is the background to the yaksha's separation; in Chhayavad, it becomes a projection of the self. Nature in this tradition is romanticised.

Subhadra's images of nature are fundamentally different:

In Avva, "the sun rising before the cock's cry burns in Avva's eyes": sunrise signifies not poetic beauty but the beginning of labour. The sun does not awaken the mother; it scorches her.

In The Edge of a Sari, "in the rain the sari's edge becomes an umbrella of golden-shower blossoms": the golden-shower flower might be an object of beauty for an upper-caste poet; here it represents practical shelter.

In Gleaning, dust, cracks in stones and soil are the landscapes in which Dalit women work—landscapes the Chhayavadi poet never saw.

In this way, Subhadra dismantles the pastoral-romantic ideology that regards the countryside as a haven of peace. In The Country and the City, Raymond Williams shows how pastoral romanticism functions as a class ideology that renders labour invisible. Subhadra's poems make that invisible labour visible.

11. Silence and Absence in Poetry

In the work of both poets, what remains unsaid is no less important than what is spoken.

In Bhimanna's Burning Huts, the killer is never named: "religion" is an abstract force. This strategic anonymity is a form of literary diplomacy. When the killer is a system rather than an individual, naming a person is unnecessary, for the system remains unchanged by that name.

In Subhadra's Avva, the mother's voice is absent. She sings, but we do not hear her song; she speaks, but we do not know her words. The silence symbolises the historical absence of Dalit women, who were never treated as subjects and agents in history, only as objects.

Jacques Derrida's notion of the trace suggests that meaning resides not only in presence but also in the marks of absence. The silences in Subhadra's poetry—Avva's unheard lullabies and unrecorded words—are traces in which Dalit women's history is inscribed.

12. Anger, Grief and Dignity: Three Emotional Registers

Across these nine poems—five by Bhimanna and four by Subhadra—three principal emotional registers appear:

Anger, in Bhimanna's Burning Huts and My Hereditary Rights. This is philosophical anger: cultural rather than merely personal.

Grief, in Subhadra's Avva and Gleaning. It is collective grief for the lost lives of an entire generation.

Dignity, in the closing lines of The Edge of a Sari and the final declaration of My Hereditary Rights. This is dignity that has been won—not bestowed through pity, but asserted as a right.

In the Poetics, Aristotle discusses catharsis, a purgation of emotion. In Dalit poetry, however, catharsis has a different character. It is not intended to cleanse the spectator's emotions; it calls for the moral cleansing of society. Ambedkar said: "I measure the progress of a community by the degree of

progress which women have achieved." Judged by this standard, these poems put society on trial and find it wanting.

13. The Maithili Literary Tradition and the Relevance of Dalit Poetry

The translation of these Telugu Dalit poems into Maithili through the magazine Videha is a literary and cultural project whose significance goes beyond translation as a technical achievement.

The Dalit voice has historically occupied a marginal position in Maithili literature. The canon of Maithili writing recognised by the Sahitya Akademi has generally been centred on Brahmin and Kayastha writers, from Vidyapati into the modern period. Following the movement for a parallel stream of Maithili literature, it became possible to situate the "Bidesiya" in Vidyapati's songs in a period prior to Jyotirishwar. [Appendix 1: A Theory of Criticism for Original and Translated Dalit Prose and Verse in Maithili; Appendix 2: A Critical Evaluation of Vidyapati's Bidesiya; Appendix 3: Vidyapati, the Earliest Poet of Maithili (Before Jyotirishwar)—Gajendra Thakur; Appendix 4: Vidyapati's Bidesiya—Pia Desantar—A Parallel World of Maithili Drama Beyond Bidapat Dance.] In this context, translating Telugu Dalit women's poetry into Maithili constitutes an intervention within the established literary tradition.

These translations tell Maithili readers that the realities of Dalit women are not confined to the Telugu-speaking world: they are equally present in Mithila. To recognise geographic specificity (the Telugu context) and social universality (the oppression of Dalit women) simultaneously is the most consequential literary-political decision of this translation project.

The poems are living evidence of the vision represented by Videha's parallel literary movement: a vision reaching beyond the accepted canon, rich in folk traditions and inclusive of Dalit women's voices.

14. Final Synthesis: Towards a New Poetics

Together, these nine poems by Bhimanna and Subhadra establish fundamental principles of Dalit poetics, principles substantially different from those of Western and upper-caste Indian aesthetics:

First, democracy of poetic subject matter. Curing hides, gleaning grain from the earth and the edge of an old sari are as worthy of poetry as the yaksha's separation in Meghaduta or Shraddha in Kamayani.

Second, the ethical acceptance of emotion. Anger, disgust and grief are treated as incomplete in certain readings of rasa theory, which place shanta rasa highest. In Dalit poetry, anger is ethically necessary.

Third, the inseparability of politics and beauty. "Art for art's sake" is meaningless in Dalit poetry. A poem is a social act: testimony, accusation and a call to liberation at once.

Fourth, respect for local knowledge. Golden-shower blossoms, tamarind, Maisamma Devi and the landa belong to a Dalit epistemology older than, and at times superior to, book learning.

Fifth, the body as political ground. The Dalit woman's body—which burns, tires, decays and weeps—is the terrain on which caste, class and gender operate simultaneously. Making that body visible in poetry is a political act.

Closing Reflections

In "The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action", Audre Lorde writes that silence will not save us: "Your silence will not protect you." Boyi Bhimanna and J. Subhadra both break that silence: Bhimanna the silence of history, Subhadra the silence of everyday life.

Their voices travel from one language to another, from Telugu into Maithili. Translation here is not simply linguistic transfer; it is an act of solidarity in which one Dalit community hears, recognises and keeps alive the voice of another in its own language.

In this sense, these nine poems by Bhimanna and Subhadra are not merely translations added to Maithili literature. They sow the seeds of a new poetic tradition.

Criticism of Dalit Women's Poetry: Two Poems by Challapalli Swaroopa Rani

Mankenapuvvu and Hands Turned to Earth

Preliminary Remarks

Challapalli Swaroopa Rani is a distinctive voice in Telugu Dalit women's poetry, bringing a new dimension to the poetic tradition of Bhimanna and Subhadra. Whereas Bhimanna works on the historical and mythological plane, and Subhadra on that of objects, labour and motherhood, Swaroopa Rani occupies a third space: she centres the transformation of individual consciousness. Her poetry begins with "I" and ends with "I"—but the "I" at the two ends of the journey is not the same.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

Mankenapuvvu

The poem has a three-tiered narrative structure. At the first level, its opening establishes a central metaphor: a blue bird caught in a thorny thicket. At the second and longest level there is an anaphoric sequence—the poetic technique of repeatedly opening with the same word—built on "when ... then", repeated six times. At the third level, the poem abruptly turns: "But when my endurance is exhausted", and culminates in an explosive declaration.

This three-tiered structure resembles the dialectical pattern of thesis, antithesis and synthesis (proposition, negation and reconciliation). Yet it differs from Hegelian dialectics in a crucial respect: the synthesis here is no compromise; it is rebellion.

In the six repetitions of "when ... then", it is worth noting that each "then" voices a desire for self-negation: to sink like a seed, to close the nose, to shrink into a fist, to pour lead, to bury the head. These five distinct images of self-denial together produce an accumulation of suffering (the weight of many pains gathered into one). It is precisely the intensity of this accumulated suffering, however, that makes the final eruption credible.

Hands Turned to Earth

The poem follows a chronology—from dawn to dusk, from youth to decay. But this chronology is not simply linear: it is spiral-shaped, moving round and round, ascending and descending. The same day recurs, the same year recurs, the same life recurs. This repetitive spiral generates a profound nihilism (a feeling that life has no meaning): no change, no end.

Compared with Subhadra's Avva, both are poems of mothers and both describe labour; but Avva adopts the daughter's point of view, whereas Hands Turned to Earth adopts the perspective of a third-person witness. The distinction matters: here Swaroopa Rani regards the mother not through affection alone but through the eyes of justice.

2. Central Metaphors: Bird, Flower and Earth

The Blue Bird and the Silk-Cotton Flower

The two principal images in Mankenapuvvu—the blue bird trapped in a thorny thicket and the red silk-cotton flower blossoming at the end—trace a chromatic journey, an emotional progression through colour. Blue, the bird's colour, symbolises sadness, bondage and an unfulfilled longing for the sky. Red, the flower's colour, symbolises rebellion, blood and vital energy.

The silk-cotton flower (semar) carries a distinctive resonance in Telugu-Andhra culture: it blossoms on a thorn-bearing tree, and in winter, when the leaves have fallen, its brilliant red flowers stand out alone. It is a cultural emblem of flowering under adversity. Swaroopa Rani transforms this indigenous symbolism into a metaphor for Dalit women's consciousness.

The phoenix of Western poetry—the legendary bird reborn after burning—offers a parallel, but the phoenix is reduced to ash and then rises. Swaroopa Rani's protagonist is not incinerated: she flowers among the thorns themselves. The distinction is significant. Liberation for a Dalit woman comes not through destruction but through transformation.

Hands Turned to Earth

The titular metaphor of Hands Turned to Earth has several dimensions. "Hands turned to earth"—hands driven into the soil through labour—is a literal description. Yet the phrase also contains both becoming earth (the devaluation of human personhood) and being made from earth (an elemental identity).

In Gleaning, Subhadra searches the earth for grains. In Hands Turned to Earth, Swaroopa Rani watches the woman herself dissolve into earth. This intensification is important: when labour becomes so relentless that labourer and soil merge, objectification—the treatment of a person as an object—has reached its extreme.

In the Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts, Marx describes alienated labour, in which workers become estranged from their work, their humanity and nature. Swaroopa Rani's "hands turned to earth" are the bodily emblem of this estrangement.

3. An Analysis of the "When … Then" Sequence

The sixfold "when … then" sequence of Mankenapuvvu supplies a taxonomy of oppression—a list of its different levels. Each "when" introduces a different dimension:

First, control over domestic aesthetics: not to wear kohl or a forehead mark. This is the most intimate level, control over one's own body.

Second, spatial control: the "stinking village"—the physical enclosure of the Dalit settlement.

Third, educational exclusion: caste-based rejection at the threshold of higher education.

Fourth, stigmatisation through reservations: "I come through the quota"—making affirmative-action provisions a weapon of humiliation.

Fifth, sexual objectification (treating a woman merely as an object of pleasure): not fit for marriage, only for sexual desire.

Together these five levels reveal the Dalit woman's encirclement on all sides—home, village, education, work and marriage. The realism of this enclosure accords with Patricia Hill Collins's concept of the matrix of domination, which understands oppression not as a single force but as interlocking systems.

Especially important is the reference to the stigma surrounding reservations, absent from the poetry of Bhimanna and Subhadra. Swaroopa Rani encompasses contemporary Dalit experience: even after entering education and public employment, the Dalit woman continues to be branded a "quota beneficiary". It is a newer form of twenty-first-century oppression, preserving old hierarchies in a new vocabulary.

4. The Politics of the Body: Two Different Paths

The body is present in both poems, but follows two different paths.

In Mankenapuvvu, the body is the site of capacity and rebellion. "I shall burst into flower", "I shall flow forth": the body that was caught in thorns until the end finally gains the power of self-determination, the right to decide for itself.

In Hands Turned to Earth, the body is the site of exhaustion and consumption. "She who once shone like a marigold / grows pale as a branch of withered leaves": this body is ruined by the double consumption of labour and patriarchy.

The two paths suggest a generational difference. The "I" of Mankenapuvvu may be an educated, aware and rebellious Dalit woman of a new generation; the "she" of Hands Turned to Earth may be an uneducated, uncomprehending and exhausted Dalit woman of an older one. Both are products of the same system, but they differ in consciousness.

In The Wretched of the Earth, Frantz Fanon identifies two levels of colonised consciousness: one that has internalised the system and another that has begun to reject it. Swaroopa Rani presents both modes of consciousness in a single collection, through two poems.

5. The Figure of the Husband: A Comparison

The husband appears in both poems, but in different forms.

In Mankenapuvvu—"At home, male control slaps one cheek"—the husband is a nameless force, an equal participant in the caste system. Neither name nor face: only power.

In Hands Turned to Earth—"the husband is ready to drink her sweat like liquor" and "at dusk she endures blows from her husband's hands and feet"—the husband is a tangible oppressor, present in daily life.

This contrast matters in literary and political terms. In the first poem patriarchy is structural, a system; in the second it is interpersonal, a relation between two individuals. Both are true, and together they create a fuller portrait of patriarchy: it is at once an institution and a person.

In Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center, bell hooks argues that feminist movements sometimes see patriarchy only as a structure and give too little weight to violence by individual men—or reverse the mistake. Together, Swaroopa Rani's poems reject this false binary.

6. Final Images: Two Opposed Endings

Mankenapuvvu ends in triumph:

"I shall blossom like the mankenapuvvu! / I shall flow like a stream, / crossing the forest of affliction."

The conclusion gives readers emotional catharsis (the release or purification of feeling after suffering): the experience of victory after pain. But this catharsis is not cheaply earned. It follows the entire poem's accumulated suffering, and therefore carries exceptional weight.

Hands Turned to Earth ends tragically:

"Along life's stony, barren road— / carrying the cross of hunger."

The word "cross" is crucial. It borrows from Christian symbolism: Jesus carrying the cross. Here, however, it is secularised. The Dalit woman continues to carry her cross without any assurance of redemption or resurrection. It is a crucifixion without resurrection—an image still crueller than its Christian antecedent.

In The Myth of Sisyphus, Albert Camus describes the philosophy of absurdity (life has no predetermined meaning): Sisyphus pushes his rock uphill over and over, only to see it fall again. Camus writes that one must imagine Sisyphus happy. But this existential solution is not available to Swaroopa Rani's protagonist, because Camus's Sisyphus is an abstract philosophical figure whereas her protagonist is historical, material and embodied.

7. Comparing Swaroopa Rani with Subhadra: Similarities and Differences

Both poets make Dalit women's lives the subject of poetry, but their poetics differ in several important respects:

Pace: Subhadra's poetry moves slowly and meditatively, giving full attention to each object and each moment. Swaroopa Rani's verse is rapid and impassioned, as though a dam were breaking.

Perspective: Subhadra bears witness from within the life she describes. Swaroopa Rani is an internal witness in Mankenapuvvu but an empathetic external witness in Hands Turned to Earth, observing another woman's life.

Resolution: Subhadra's The Edge of a Sari has an unresolved, open ending. Swaroopa Rani's Mankenapuvvu offers a clear resolution—rebellion and flowering. In this sense Swaroopa Rani is more manifesto-like: her poetry contains an element of political declaration.

8. Distinctive Features of Language and Style

One noteworthy feature of Mankenapuvvu is its relative lack of particularised sensory detail. The poem works primarily on emotional and conceptual levels rather than through concrete sensations. It differs here from Subhadra's verse, with its fleshy golden-shower pods, tamarind seeds and vessel cushions, all tangible and perceptible to the senses.

In Hands Turned to Earth, however, sensory abundance is present: "mud up to the knees", "entrails dancing violently in the belly", "the music of Brahmin utensils". Swaroopa Rani therefore commands both modes of expression and selects between them according to context.

"The music of Brahmin utensils"—calling the sound of washing dishes "music"—is bitter irony. Upper-class aesthetics hears music in the violin and sitar; for a Dalit woman, the first "music" of dawn is the clatter of brass vessels. This overturning of aesthetic values demonstrates Swaroopa Rani's poetic intelligence.

9. All Three Poets: An Integrated View

At this third stage of the critical study, viewing Bhimanna, Subhadra and Swaroopa Rani together reveals a triangular structure within Telugu Dalit poetry:

Bhimanna—the poet of history and philosophy—questions the historical and mythological foundations of caste at the broadest level.

Subhadra—the poet of labour and objects—renders visible at the micro level the concrete facts of daily life, one object and one act of labour at a time.

Swaroopa Rani—the poet of consciousness and transformation—works at an intermediate level between history and everyday experience, capturing individual consciousness, the inward experience of oppression and the transformation of that consciousness.

Together the three encompass Dalit women's experience from outside to inside, from history to the present, and from suffering to rebellion.

Conclusion

These two poems by Challapalli Swaroopa Rani—Mankenapuvvu and Hands Turned to Earth—offer a striking expression of the conflict between hope and despair in Dalit women's poetry. Mankenapuvvu declares: I shall flower,

despite the thorns. Hands Turned to Earth replies: without structural change, such flowering cannot happen.

Taken together, the poems form a complete political message: individual revolt is possible and necessary, but until structures change, the protagonist of Hands Turned to Earth will be born again and again and will die again and again carrying her cross.

This double truth—the possibility of individual liberation and the necessity of collective liberation—is Swaroopa Rani's greatest poetic achievement.

Criticism of Dalit Women's Poetry: Three Poems by Darishe Shashinirmala

I Am the One Who Lost Everything; I Am Draping Myself in Menstrual Cloth; A Dalit Woman

Preliminary Remarks

Darishe Shashinirmala is among the fiercest and most confrontational voices in Telugu Dalit women's poetry. Going beyond Bhimanna's historical-philosophical analysis, Subhadra's poetry of labour and objects, and Swaroopa Rani's transformation of individual consciousness, Shashinirmala occupies an entirely different poetic terrain. She fights on three fronts at once: against upper-caste men, against Dalit men, and against upper-caste women. In this threefold struggle, her poetry establishes a political position exceptional within the Telugu Dalit poetic tradition.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

I Am the One Who Lost Everything

The poem takes the form of dialogue—a poetic representation of direct speech between two parties—but an extraordinary dialogue in which the other side never answers. “You”, an upper-caste woman, are the poem's sole addressee. The poet speaks to her but does not await a reply, because that reply is impossible.

This one-sided dialogue, in which only one party speaks, is a distinctive poetic device. It differs from the soliloquy of Shakespearean drama, which reveals an internal conflict. This is not a soliloquy but an unheard dialogue. The poet speaks and the other party does not listen. The structural deafness reveals the true nature of upper-caste women's feminism.

The last five lines take the form of questions—“Will you step down one step?”, “Will we walk on the same footpath?” These are not merely rhetorical questions but a real test. The poet compels the upper-caste woman to make a concrete choice.

I Am Draping Myself in Menstrual Cloth

This poem's structure is the most intricate and multilayered of the three. It is at once a personal cry of anguish, a political manifesto and a historical document. It operates on three levels:

First, personal bodily experience: menstruation, sweat and humiliation at the well. Second, sociopolitical analysis: the media, police, courts and caste violence. Third, historical evidence: the names of actual victims—Alisamma, Muthavva and Mahadevamma.

These three levels become inseparable in the poem: the personal, the social and the historical speak in a single breath. In this threefold unity lies the source of Shashinirmala's poetic power.

A Dalit Woman

The poem is structured as an ever-expanding inventory of accusations. Each line adds a further humiliation, a further exploitation, until the catalogue threatens to crush the reader beneath its weight. Then comes a sudden reversal: "Now I am opening my mouth and eyes." It converts the accumulated weight of the entire poem into revolt.

Structurally, this reverses the classical sonnet tradition. A sonnet ordinarily introduces a problem and then moves towards a resolution. Here the presentation of the problem is so prolonged and intense that it becomes the poem's principal body, while resolution appears explosively in no more than two lines.

2. The Politics of the Titles

In all three poems, the title is itself a political statement.

"I Am the One Who Lost Everything" contains ironic self-accusation: the speaker appears to blame herself, but ironically. She says, Yes, I have lost—but who is responsible for this loss? The title offers no answer; it interrogates the reader.

"I Am Draping Myself in Menstrual Cloth": the term "menstrual" is deeply stigmatised within the Hindu-Brahmanical system of purity and pollution. Making it the title is an intentional provocation, designed to discomfort the hearer. To drape this cloth over the "false arguments" and "cunning" of the very society that despises it is an act of poetic retribution.

"A Dalit Woman" is the simplest title, and for that reason the most powerful. "A", the indefinite singular, says that this is not the story of one particular person but of all Dalit women. The title is personal and universal at once.

3. A Critique of Upper-Caste Women's Feminism: I Am the One Who Lost Everything

This poem exhibits a rare kind of poetic courage in Telugu—and indeed Indian—Dalit literature: it addresses an upper-caste woman directly and questions her feminist claims.

Its central episode is this: an upper-caste woman, perhaps the poet's employer or neighbour, says to her husband, "You fool!", apparently speaking up for the Dalit woman. Yet this same supposedly feminist upper-caste woman does not restrain her own daughter's aggression, regards the Dalit woman as a "subordinate", and ultimately offers to "advocate" for her only when the Dalit woman herself has "clenched her fist".

This lays bare the double standard of a feminism that speaks for Dalit women but in practice sustains caste hierarchy. In Sister Outsider, Audre Lorde critiques the racial blindness of white feminism and argues that claims of solidarity among women are hollow unless differences of class and caste are acknowledged. Shashinirmala's poem gives this principle concrete form in the Indian reality of caste.

In her discussion of Brahmanical patriarchy (which reveals caste and gender to be two wings of a single system), Uma Chakravarti argues that upper-caste women in India are simultaneously victims of patriarchy by virtue of gender and beneficiaries of caste hierarchy by virtue of caste. Shashinirmala's poem exposes this contradiction without theoretical disguise, in its naked reality.

"As long as there is only man or only woman, there is no problem": this line is the philosophical essence of the poem. When identity remains one-dimensional—gender alone or caste alone—compromise is possible. But when the Dalit woman insists upon her multidimensional identity of caste, gender and class, the struggle over lines of exclusion begins.

4. Body, Purity and Resistance: I Am Draping Myself in Menstrual Cloth

The central metaphor of the poem—the menstrual cloth—performs several poetic functions simultaneously.

The Demolition of the Myth of Purity

Under the Hindu varna-ashrama system, a menstruating woman is deemed impure. To "drape" oneself in that cloth, to cover oneself with it, reverses the relation: to cast this "impure" cloth over the falsehoods of the society that calls a woman impure because of it is to turn impurity itself into a weapon.

Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection is pertinent once again: society recoils from what transgresses bodily boundaries—blood, bodily discharge, excrement—and maintains social hierarchies through that recoil. Shashinirmala transforms the abject into a political weapon.

Historical Evidence

At the poem's end, the references to Alisamma, Muthavva and Mahadevamma —women who, as the poem relates, were stripped and paraded by upper-caste men—provide an historical anchor, tying the poetry to concrete events. The poem is no longer merely an individual lyrical outpouring: it becomes a vessel of collective memory.

Walter Benjamin's concept of dangerous memory deserves recalling here; in this instance the memory is more dangerous still, for these are not abstract historical facts but the names of actual women.

Institutional Failure

"Neither the police baton / nor the gaze of the court / has anything to do with my flayed skin": these lines explicitly expose the state's bias towards caste. Police and courts, conventionally symbols of impartial justice, appear here as indifferent or hostile institutions in the life of a Dalit woman.

Michel Foucault's account of power and knowledge—which shows how institutions of justice, medicine and other fields are not neutral but instruments of relations of power—takes poetic shape here. Shashinirmala presents this philosophical insight in the language of verse without recourse to technical theoretical terminology.

5. Threefold Oppression: A Dalit Woman

A Dalit Woman is among the most politically complex poems of Telugu Dalit literature because it confronts three oppressors at the same time.

Its first part, from the opening to "my body's strength drips away drop by drop", describes oppression by upper-caste men.

Its second part, beginning "Why? / Our own Dalit people ...", invokes oppression by Dalit men: "They make me into a clothesline for drying their clothes", "to keep me as a post and peg for their skulls".

Its third part, beginning "Why? / Our own womenfolk ...", invokes oppression by upper-caste women: "They make me the border of their upper-caste sari."

Acknowledging this threefold oppression is an exceptionally bold act within Dalit women's poetry. To acknowledge oppression by Dalit men has long been taboo within the politics of Dalit solidarity. Shashinirmala breaks that taboo.

Babasaheb Ambedkar stated that Dalit women occupy the most pitiable position among Dalits: excluded from wider society because of caste, from the Dalit community because of gender, and from upper-caste women through class. Shashinirmala's poem offers poetic testimony to that insight.

Sharmila Rege's Dalit-feminist standpoint—the argument that Dalit women's perspectives carry an epistemological privilege because they live at the deepest intersection of oppression—becomes poetry here. "A Dalit Woman" speaks precisely where the three systems of oppression meet.

6. Metaphorical Analysis: The Politics of the Body

Across all three poems, bodily metaphors are extraordinarily intense and varied.

In I Am the One Who Lost Everything, "They plucked and tore at me like thorns and grass until they made me a chicken" is a metaphor of animalisation, the reduction of a human being to an animal. The "chicken" is the creature plucked without resistance.

In I Am Draping Myself in Menstrual Cloth, "My mouth, /which constantly pours out sweat, /knows what it means to live invisibly": here the mouth is the site both of expression and of suppression. To sweat is to labour, and labour ought to make a person visible; yet society renders the Dalit woman invisible.

In A Dalit Woman, "They urinate into my joined hands" is the rawest, most degrading image. Hands joined in supplication traditionally signify reverence; to urinate into them is the utmost desecration of the sacred. Shashinirmala does not temper the image poetically, because the reality itself is without restraint.

Frantz Fanon's concept of the colonised body—the insight that colonialism assaults the body first, humiliating and controlling it in order to break the spirit—applies to all three poems.

7. Language and Style: A Poetics of Ferocity

Shashinirmala's language is fiercer, more direct and more confrontational than that of the preceding poets. This ferocity has both literary and political significance.

Subhadra's language bears contemplative witness: she observes and makes visible. Swaroopa Rani's language is an impassioned declaration: she speaks through the rupture. Shashinirmala's is direct accusation: she names, points her finger and looks her addressee in the eye.

"They put a halter through my nose and make me perform": a halter belongs to an animal, not a person. The metaphor directly names the politics of animalisation, the social process by which a Dalit woman is reduced from human being to beast.

"They make me a buffalo to be milked": casting the exploitation of labour as the milking of livestock joins in one image Marx's extraction of surplus value (the appropriation by owners of value created by labourers) and caste exploitation.

8. Comparison with Earlier Poets: An Integrated Poetic Genealogy

The five poets studied in this series—Bhimanna, Subhadra, Swaroopa Rani and Shashinirmala—together form a comprehensive poetic genealogy of Telugu Dalit verse:

Bhimanna—a rereading of history and mythology; a wide-angle perspective; the restoration of Dalit identity.

Subhadra—labour, objects and motherhood; a close-up perspective; the poetic documentation of everyday life.

Swaroopa Rani—the transformation of individual consciousness; an intermediate perspective between the individual and social; the dialectic of hope and despair.

Shashinirmala—a threefold struggle; a confrontational perspective; the exposure of contradictions within feminism.

Together these four poets trace a dialectical journey: beginning in history (Bhimanna), descending into everyday life (Subhadra), awakening personal consciousness (Swaroopa Rani), and finally confronting oppression from every direction (Shashinirmala).

Conclusion

Shashinirmala's three poems carry Dalit women's poetry into new political territory. Without verbal restraint or diplomacy, they say what is hardest to say: Dalit men's oppression, the hypocrisy of upper-caste feminism and the caste bias of state institutions.

In this poetry, beauty lies in anger, form in ferocity, and philosophy in concrete bodily realities. It is a culmination of that Dalit-feminist poetics which draws strength from the intellectual traditions of Sharan Kumar Limbale, Omprakash Valmiki and Ambedkar.

The last line—"Let us see what wonders they perform"—poses a challenge. The Dalit woman is no longer a spectator but a questioner. The question is addressed to society, feminism and the Dalit movement alike; answering it is the work not of literature alone but of history.

Criticism of Dalit Women's Poetry: A Poem by M. Gauri

Henna-Stained Hands

Preliminary Remarks

M. Gauri is an entirely distinctive voice within Telugu Dalit women's poetry. While Shashinirmala writes the poetry of threefold struggle, Subhadra creates a poetry of labour and objects, and Bhimanna rereads mythology, Gauri adopts a strategy different from them all: she overturns mythological narrative and speaks directly to Krishna. The dialogue becomes a poetic declaration of selfhood by a Dalit woman working with hides.

The poetic complexity, counter-mythological reading, formal accomplishment and political daring concentrated in this one poem place it among the most outstanding works of Telugu Dalit verse.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

The Structure of Direct Address

The poem is written in the second person—speaking directly to "you"—and the "you" is Lord Krishna himself. This is an exceptionally bold poetic decision. Addressing Krishna has a long history in Indian poetry—in Mirabai, Surdas and Jayadeva—but in those texts the speaker is a devotee and the relationship is one of Krishna's superiority and the worshipper's humility.

Gauri reverses that hierarchy. She addresses Krishna not as a worshipper but as a challenger. "Can you look at it without fainting?", "Can you kiss my blood-smeared hands?" These are not questions of devotion but tests.

A Three-Part Poetic Arc

The poem is divided into three clearly defined movements:

The first movement, from "My lane is made of flesh and blood" to "a game of piercing a sturdy bull straight through", establishes the world of work: the daily labour of a woman who works with hides.

The second movement, from "You, heroic Krishna!" to "behind the curtain of hide and skin?", stages a counter-mythological dialogue. It questions three images of Krishna: destroyer of demonic illusion, lover of cowherd girls and flute player.

The third movement, from "My lane is no longer suitable for domesticated puppies" to the end, is the Dalit woman's declaration of herself, reclaiming her labour, body and dignity.

These three arcs constitute a dialectical structure of thesis, antithesis and synthesis (proposition, negation and reconciliation). But the synthesis here is not a middle way: it is rebellious self-affirmation.

2. Counter-Mythological Reading: The Rejection of Three Images of Krishna

Within a single poem, Gauri successively addresses three mythological versions of Krishna and sets the reality of Dalit women's lives against each of them.

First Image: Krishna, Destroyer of Demonic Illusion

"You, heroic Krishna! / Who destroyed the demoness by suckling at her breast": the reference is to the killing of Putana. In the Puranic story Krishna kills Putana, who offers him poisoned milk; the act symbolises divine heroism.

Gauri challenges that "heroism": "I shall show you two strips of flesh and a vessel of blood. / Can you look at them without fainting?" The labour a woman who works with hides performs daily—handling flesh and blood—is more real and more courageous than Krishna's supposed "heroism". The

comparison of mythological heroism with the everyday labour of Dalits is bitter and devastatingly truthful.

Second Image: Krishna, Lover of the Cowherd Girls

"You who deceitfully stole the clothes of the cowherd girls": this alludes to the episode of the stolen garments, regarded in the devotional tradition as divine play, or lila.

Gauri reads this "divine play" through the lens of sexual exploitation, then challenges Krishna: "Can you steal my heart, / which I have kept safe / behind the curtain of hide and skin?" The heart is safeguarded behind a "curtain of hide and skin", an extraordinarily complex metaphor. Hide and skin stand for the occupational identity of a Dalit woman working with leather, an identity society considers "impure". The very "impure" identity becomes protective armour against Krishna's intrigues of love.

Third Image: Krishna, Player of the Flute

"You who sent messages of desire through the flute, / can you read the message of love I have written on the threshold with my tender fingers?" Krishna's flute represents divine love in devotional poetry. Here, however, the Dalit woman's love message, written on the threshold, is more tangible, more real and more human.

The "threshold", or doorway, is a symbol of boundary. The Dalit woman writes on the threshold: neither inside an upper-caste household nor outside it. Love written on the threshold is marginal love, the experience of the social periphery.

Gauri presents more dramatically, as poetic dialogue, the tradition of counter-mythological reading developed by Bhimanna, who reverses the premises of Puranic narrative to interpret it from a Dalit perspective.

3. The Multilayered Meaning of the Title

"Henna-Stained Hands" is a profoundly double-edged title.

In the first sense, henna is a symbol of wedding festivities in Indian culture: adornment, good fortune and love. "Henna-stained hands" are hands immersed in celebration.

In the second sense, the "henna" within the poem is actually blood. "Can you kiss my blood-smeared hands, / with no henna applied?" Here blood equals henna. The blood on the hands of the leather-working Dalit woman is the henna of labour, not of marriage.

Such an inversion of symbolism—turning an auspicious sign into a sign of labour's reality—is an excellent example of Dalit aesthetics. In upper-caste culture, henna signifies beauty and celebration. For a Dalit woman working with hides, it signifies blood and toil. Gauri gathers both senses into one word.

4. The Metaphor of Hide and Skin: Reclaiming Dalit Identity

The poem's most powerful movement is its final section, in which hide and skin, considered "impure" by society, become the central metaphor of reclamation:

"When my hide is washed with golden-shower blossom, / wiping away the stains of your fingers— / it becomes a drum, / resounding with pure music."

Three transformations unfold in these lines:

First, the marks of Krishna's fingers—of the Krishna who stole the cowherd girls' garments and played the flute—are inscribed on the hide. In other words, the claims of upper-caste culture have left their imprint on the Dalit body.

Second, when the hide is washed with golden-shower blossom (which Subhadra also uses in Landa), the marks are erased. Indigenous knowledge removes the imprint of upper-caste cultural claims.

Third, the cleansed hide becomes a drum that resounds with pure music. This is crucial: the very hide that society regards as "impure" in the leather worker's hands produces "pure music" when made into a drum.

It is a complete demolition of the purity-pollution myth, achieved not through argument but through metaphor. The drum also appeared in Swaroopa Rani's Landa, where it symbolised the husband's labour. Here the drum symbolises the Dalit woman's identity: her very body, once condemned as "impure", becomes a source of music.

Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection, in which society marks bodily fluids and animal flesh as "abject" and "impure" and thereby maintains social hierarchy, receives a poetic reply. Gauri transforms the "abject" into the "beautiful" and the "impure" into "pure music".

5. The Metaphor of Play and the Meaning of Courage

The poem opens with an invitation: "Won't you come and play with me?" It sounds like an innocent child's invitation, but immediately it becomes clear that the game involves piercing an actual bull.

"Not that coward's game of bullocks in a procession; / I shall show you a game of courage." The lines establish a hierarchy of acts. Dressing up and parading castrated bullocks in religious processions is called a "coward's game". The Dalit leather-working woman's task—piercing a robust bull—is called real courage.

In Indian folk tradition, jallikattu, the contest involving bulls, is a display of bravery. Gauri turns that folk tradition into a metaphor for Dalit women's labour and challenges upper-caste definitions of cultural heroism: true courage resides not in religious processions but in daily work.

6. "An Unbowed Spine": A Poetic Declaration of Dalit Dignity

"Come, / if you can, / I shall teach you how to select bones— / I shall show you an unbowed spine."

These lines contain the philosophical and political essence of the poem.

"Selecting bones", the professional work of a Dalit woman working with hides, becomes an act of transmitting knowledge. She wants to teach Krishna. The teacher is the Dalit woman, the pupil is Krishna: a complete reversal of hierarchy.

"An unbowed spine" carries two meanings. Literally, the backbone of an animal, straight and not bent; figuratively, the Dalit woman's self-respect, which has not bowed.

Babasaheb Ambedkar said: "Life should be great rather than long." Gauri's Dalit woman is not merely long-lived: she is unconquerable.

7. "No Sin": The Rejection of Religious Morality

"It is no sin of water turned to mud; / it is no sin of the 'criminal' hide."

The quotation marks around "criminal hide" are significant. A society that calls hide "criminal" thereby reveals the falsity of its own morality. Gauri rejects that morality outright.

Brahmanical religious texts regard the work of a leather worker as sinful, a consequence of actions in a previous birth. Gauri directly denies this doctrine of karmic retribution: "It is no sin." Those two words—"no sin"—constitute a poetic manifesto against the entire moral and economic system of Brahmanism.

There is an echo here of Friedrich Nietzsche's revaluation of morality, which argues that prevailing moral codes are not truths but rules constructed to serve those in power. Yet Gauri reaches this conclusion not by reading Nietzsche's philosophy but through lived reality.

8. Water as Metaphor: A New Definition of Purity

"When water turns into vapour, becoming a dark cloud to shower drops of lightning, / then the purity of the lane becomes transparent."

Physical science and poetic metaphor merge in these lines. As water becomes vapour it turns invisible; it then becomes cloud and releases lightning, assuming the form of power.

The lane of the Dalit woman, deemed "impure" by society, reveals its holiness as "transparent", that is, manifest, when this transformation occurs. Transparency means the disclosure of truth.

The metaphor offers a poetic rendering of the Hegelian dialectic, in which conflict among opposing elements gives birth to a new truth. Yet here it is not abstract philosophy but the concrete reality of soil and water.

9. Comparison with Bhimanna: Two Forms of Counter-Mythological Reading

Both Bhimanna's My Hereditary Rights and Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands undertake a rereading of mythology. Their strategies, however, differ:

Bhimanna offers a historical argument about the Puranas: Vyasa, Vashishtha and Matsyagandhi were actually of Dalit origin, and this historical truth must be brought into view. His method is a scholarly rereading.

Gauri stages dramatic dialogue with mythology: she addresses Krishna directly, challenges him and invites him into her lane. Her strategy is poetic confrontation.

Together they present the full spectrum of counter-mythological readings within Dalit verse: an assault through argument and an assault through dialogue.

10. Affinity with Subhadra's Landa: The Symbol of the Drum

As noted above, both Subhadra's Landa and Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands use the symbol of the drum, but in different contexts.

In Landa, "To make creaking shoes and drums— / he beats out sweet rhythms on the drum": the drum represents the husband's craft. The woman's labour is transformed into the husband's art, carrying the bitterness of alienated labour.

In Henna-Stained Hands, the drum is a symbol of the Dalit woman's own identity. Her body, labour and skin are the source of pure music. Here there is no alienation from labour, but a celebration of it.

These different uses of the drum demonstrate the polyphony of a single symbol in Dalit women's poetry.

Conclusion

M. Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands is a landmark of Telugu Dalit poetry. Within this one poem:

Myth and modernity unite: Krishna and the Dalit leather-working woman stand in the same place.

Form and politics unite: the beauty of metaphor and social accusation are spoken in one breath.

The individual and collective unite: the voice of one woman becomes the voice of the entire Dalit leather-working community.

Finally, "it becomes a drum, / resounding with pure music". Gauri declares that the Dalit woman's body, labour and identity, all of which society calls "impure", are in fact the source of the purest music. This is not merely a poetic metaphor: it is an entire vision of civilisation.

Criticism of Dalit Women's Poetry: A Poem by Madduri Vijayashri

Alisamma's Curse

Preliminary Remarks

Madduri Vijayashri's Alisamma's Curse is an exceptional achievement in Telugu Dalit women's poetry. In this brief poem, of approximately thirty lines, such complexity of form, such concentration of history and mythology, and such political daring are brought together that it occupies a distinctive place in its genre.

Three historical moments coexist in the poem: the time of the Ramayana (the cutting of Shurpanakha's nose), contemporary history (the incident involving Alisamma) and the present (the ongoing crisis of Dalit women). This unity of three temporalities creates an extraordinary compression of poetic time.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

The Opening Premonition

The first three lines—"You may find this astonishing, / you may find this ridiculous, / you may find this deeply revolting"—form an anaphoric sequence anticipating three different responses from readers.

The construction is carefully calculated. The poet knows that three kinds of reader will approach her poem: those who find it remarkable (liberals), those who laugh (mockers) and those who recoil in disgust (reactionaries). Addressing all three at once, she declares, "But now I am a new question." Whatever the reaction, the poem's existence remains unshaken.

The Structure of Self-Identification

The poem's middle section is a progressive self-introduction, moving from the negative towards the affirmative:

First, what she does not have: she cannot sit in a reserved seat; she has no honorific title.

Second, what she does have: sorrow, being tossed about, being prey to lust.

Third, naming herself: "I am Alisamma." At this line the poem enters another register.

The movement is from negative definition to self-assertion, ultimately culminating in the proclamation of a curse.

The Final Eruption

The closing movement—"You animals! / I curse you all"—marks a sudden change of voice. A poem that has proceeded in a measured, analytical tone abruptly becomes a furious roar. This is a poetic earthquake.

2. Alisamma: Historical Person and Poetic Symbol

Alisamma was mentioned in Shashinirmala's I Am Draping Myself in Menstrual Cloth, but there she remained one name among others. Here Vijayashri makes Alisamma the speaker: she speaks for herself.

Alisamma is presented as an actual historical person, a Dalit woman from Andhra Pradesh who was publicly stripped and paraded by upper-caste men. The incident came to symbolise the oppression of Dalit women.

By making this historical person the poetic narrator, Vijayashri accomplishes two things simultaneously:

First, she transforms Alisamma from object into subject, from the person spoken about into the speaking agent. In historical accounts she was a victim whose story others told. Here she speaks herself.

Second, she makes Alisamma universal. In "I am Alisamma", the "I" is not simply one individual but all Dalit women.

Vijayashri thus offers an answer to Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question, "Can the Subaltern Speak?"—can the subaltern enter history in her own voice? Yes, in this poem: Alisamma speaks.

3. Mythological-Historical Parallel: Shurpanakha and Alisamma

The poem's boldest decision is to link the cutting of Shurpanakha's nose and Alisamma's public stripping in a single passage:

"Once my ears and nose were cut off at Lord Rama's command. / And now, more recently, / I became suffering without cause in the hands of the police."

This parallel carries several layers of meaning:

First, in both incidents the perpetrators are men, and the victims are Dalit or socially excluded women. Shurpanakha belongs to the rakshasa lineage, the "other" placed outside the mainstream; Alisamma belongs to a Dalit community, likewise treated as society's "other".

Second, state power is implicated in both. On Rama's order Lakshmana cuts the nose; Alisamma suffers at the hands of the police. The religious state of the Ramayana and the modern state perform the same function.

Third, Shurpanakha's desire was treated as a crime in the Ramayana because she wished to marry Rama or Lakshmana. Alisamma's very existence was treated as a crime. In both cases, a woman's desire or presence becomes the pretext for oppression.

Fourth, "Lord Rama": the word "Lord" is ironic. The "Lord", a deity and protector, orders violence against a woman. The line rejects morality based on religious authority.

The poem carries further the counter-mythological tradition of Bhimanna, who reread the figures of the Mahabharata. Bhimanna reinterpreted history;

Vijayashri joins history to the present in order to show that nothing has changed.

4. The Philosophy of the "New Question"

"But now I am a new question" is a profoundly significant line.

In traditional philosophy, questioning is a means and the answer is the aim. In the Socratic method, questions lead towards truth. Vijayashri, however, declares: I myself am the question.

It is an existential declaration. The Dalit woman is not an answer but a question addressed to society, the system and history. As long as she lives, the question cannot be closed.

Simone de Beauvoir's account of woman as the "Other" in The Second Sex—always defined in relation to man—becomes more complex when caste enters the picture. The Dalit woman is not merely the Other but a question demanding an answer.

5. The Poetic and Political Significance of the "Curse"

The word "curse" in both the title and final declaration is exceptionally multilayered.

The Curse in Religious Tradition

In Hindu religious tradition, the curses of sages are regarded as extraordinarily powerful. The curses of Brahma and Durvasa, for example, are irrevocable. The right to pronounce curses has traditionally belonged to upper-caste men.

Vijayashri transfers the authority to curse into the hands of a Dalit woman. This reverses the hierarchy: the one who once received curses now delivers one.

The Substance of the Curse

"I curse you all to turn into human beings— /breaking and twisting off your tails and pointed teeth."

The curse is extraordinary. Ordinarily a curse threatens destruction: die, turn to ash, become an animal. Vijayashri's curse demands transformation: become human.

There is profound philosophical irony here. The oppressors—police, upper castes, those who behave like beasts—are in truth animals. Cursing them to become human is the ultimate satire.

There is an echo of Frantz Fanon's anti-colonial philosophy, in which the coloniser or oppressor has actually lost his humanity: the victim is more human than the oppressor. Vijayashri transforms this argument into a poetic curse.

6. The Absence of an Honorific Title

"When I am called or shouted at, /no respectful title can be placed before or after my name."

These lines disclose the relationship between language and social identity. In Indian society, designations placed before or after a name—"Mrs", "Dr", "Late", caste-identifying surnames—are markers of social recognition.

When the Dalit woman speaks or cries out, she has no socially acknowledged name: no "Mrs" (marital respectability), no caste surname (assigning her a place in society), no professional title.

The linguist Pierre Bourdieu's concept of linguistic capital, which explains how language reflects relations of social power, applies here. The authority to name is itself a social power. The emptiness before and after the Dalit woman's name symbolises her absence from recognised society.

7. The Metaphor of the Reserved Seat

"Although it is empty, / I cannot sit in the seat reserved for women."

This is an exceptionally precise poetic representation of contemporary Dalit women's experience. In buses, trains and offices, a seat marked "reserved for women" should in principle be available to every woman. In practice, the Dalit woman cannot occupy it because upper-caste women or men object.

The metaphor reveals the distance between law and lived reality. The Indian Constitution guarantees equality, but socially the guarantee resembles an empty seat: present yet inaccessible.

Swaroopa Rani's stigmatisation of reservations—humiliation for having entered through a quota—and Vijayashri's inaccessible reserved seat together illustrate the contradiction between Dalit women's constitutional rights and social realities.

8. "A Wick in the Eye of the Court"

"I am Alisamma, / who lit a wick in the eye that is the court."

This metaphor possesses extraordinary poetic density.

The image of the "eye that is the court" recalls the blindfolded goddess of justice, Justitia, in Western iconography, signifying impartiality. In the Indian context, however, courts have often favoured dominant castes and classes.

Lighting a lamp's wick ordinarily spreads illumination. Lighting a wick inside an eye is an act of torture. For the Dalit woman, going to court—an act that should secure justice—becomes an experience of torment.

Hope and irony coexist in this metaphor. Alisamma went to bring light into the court, but the wick burned in that "eye", and kept burning.

9. "Even as a Woman and a Dalit, I Am Still Alive"

This line could serve as the defining statement of Dalit women's poetry.

"Even": a single word encompasses the entire history of oppression. Oppression as a woman; oppression as a Dalit; both together. "Even" means in spite of all of these.

Survival becomes a political act. Paul Gilroy considers "living, laughing, loving" a form of cultural resistance to oppression. In this sense Vijayashri's "I am still alive" means that survival itself is rebellion.

10. All Five Poets: A Final Synthesis

Across this critical series we have examined five Telugu Dalit poets—Bhimanna, Subhadra, Swaroopa Rani, Shashinirmala, Gauri and Vijayashri. Together they construct a whole universe of Dalit women's poetry:

Bhimanna—the mirror of history: overturning the received history of mythology.

Subhadra—the mirror of labour: poetry of the objects of everyday life.

Swaroopa Rani—the mirror of consciousness: the journey of individual transformation.

Shashinirmala—the mirror of struggle: threefold struggle against threefold oppression.

Gauri—the mirror of identity: transforming a supposedly "impure" identity into pure music.

Vijayashri—the mirror of justice: making the victim of history a speaking subject and turning the curse into a weapon.

These six mirrors together produce a comprehensive reflection of Dalit women's existence.

Conclusion

Madduri Vijayashri's Alisamma's Curse represents the culminating poetic moment of this entire series on Telugu Dalit poetry.

In this poem:

History speaks: Alisamma, once treated as an object, becomes the narrator.

Myth is dismantled: Rama's "lordship" and the police's "authority" are brought together in a single passage.

Language rebels: the "curse", formerly the privilege of the upper castes, becomes a Dalit woman's weapon.

A philosophy is born: staying alive is revolt; becoming a question is power.

The final words—"breaking and twisting off your tails and pointed teeth"—are a demand made of the future. Until oppressors relinquish their beastliness, the curse will remain active. The demand is addressed to society, the system and history alike.

And that question—"But now I am a new question"—is the final, unanswered and most powerful voice of this entire sequence of Telugu Dalit poetry.

Gujarati Dalit Poetry [Translated from Gujarati into English by Hemang Desai; from English into Maithili by Gajendra Thakur.

“Poster,” by Anish Garange;

“Sexual Intercourse,” by Rajendra Vadel ‘Jita’;

“Let the People Freeze” and “The Broomstick's Reproaches,” by Umesh Solanki.

Gujarati Dalit Poetry: A Critical Study of Four Poems

Anish Garange, Rajendra Vadel ‘Jita’, and Umesh Solanki

Preliminary Observations

The Gujarati Dalit poems presented in this collection, following the Telugu tradition, express Dalit experience on a different linguistic and cultural terrain. Where the woman-centred Dalit voice was prominent in the Telugu poems, the male Dalit voice is more central here; nevertheless, in Vadel's “Sexual Intercourse” the reality of Dalit women reappears.

The three poets—Garange, Vadel and Solanki—adopt three different poetic strategies: Garange employs urban realism, the concrete, sensuously apprehensible reality of city life; Vadel presents testimony concerning sexual politics; and Solanki uses the metaphor of freezing and satire directed against Gandhian ideology. Together, they construct a comprehensive urban-political portrait of Gujarati Dalit poetry.

1. Anish Garange: “Poster”

Poetic Form and Structure

“Poster” is composed in a circular structure, in which the opening line becomes the final line. “These posters with rough faces are like my mirror”: the poem begins and ends with this statement. Its circularity symbolically expresses the seemingly endless cycle of Dalit existence, from which there is no exit.

The lines between these two points—cinema banners, advertisements, condolence meetings, toilets, rallies, railway stations, rickshaws and missing-person posters—are fragments of city life. In structural terms, this is collage poetry: a mode of creating meaning by bringing apparently disconnected fragments together.

The Multiple Meanings of the Poster Metaphor

The word “poster” carries several meanings in the poem.

First, a poster is temporary. It is pasted up one day and peeled away the next morning. In society's eyes, Dalit existence is likewise treated as temporary and replaceable.

Second, a poster is public: everyone sees it, but no one pays attention. The Dalit individual is similarly visible and yet invisible.

Third, posters take many forms—cinema notices, advertisements, political rallies and missing-person notices. The Dalit individual, too, is put to different uses by different social institutions.

The "mirror" is the poem's most significant metaphor. That a poster should be the Dalit's "mirror" is an irony. A mirror supposedly gives an authentic reflection, whereas a poster is a distorted, humiliated image designed for a particular purpose. In other words, the "mirror" society holds before the Dalit is a false one.

Jacques Lacan's mirror stage, in which the child recognises its reflection and forms a sense of "I", applies here in a negative sense. The "mirror" (the poster) seen by the Dalit individual contains a distorted self-image imposed by society.

Urban Realism

"You urinate on me in 'pay-and-use' toilets": this line is strikingly direct. The pay-and-use toilet, a concrete location in urban life, becomes a metaphor for social humiliation. One must pay to enter the toilet, but urinating upon a Dalit costs nothing.

"I am a ball of wastepaper": this is self-objectification, the treatment of oneself as an object, yet it arises not from self-hatred but from the acknowledgement of social reality. The poem says: this is how society sees me.

"Khaman-khadi", a Gujarati food, marks a particular cultural geography. A "face smeared with khaman-khadi" suggests the middle-class, upper-caste image of Gujarati culture—khaman-dhokla has become an emblematic Gujarati food—being applied to a Dalit face in a humiliating, satirical fashion.

Walter Benjamin's account of urban experience, in which the modern city absorbs the human being into an assemblage of objects, becomes more complex in the Dalit urban experience: the city does not merely anonymise; it also marks people with caste stigma.

2. Rajendra Vadel 'Jita': "Sexual Intercourse"

Poetic Form: Testimony on Sexual Politics

"Sexual Intercourse" is the Gujarati counterpart to Shashinirmala's sexually political voice in the Telugu Dalit poetry series, but with an important difference: here the speaker is male, and the poem analyses sexual relations between upper-caste men and Dalit women.

This is an exceptionally bold poetic decision. Sexual relations are usually considered private matters; Vadel makes them the subject of political analysis.

The "Stinking" Body

"Your body stank of your ancestors who crushed Dalit women": this is a deeply complex line.

"Stinking": ordinarily Dalit castes are called "impure" and "foul-smelling". Vadel reverses this stigma of pollution: it is the upper-caste body that stinks of a history of the rape of Dalit women.

"Your ancestors": the phrase is crucial. This is no individual sin; it is historical exploitation continued across generations. The acts of those ancestors are physically present in the upper-caste man's body.

In this line Vadel offers a poetic representation of epigenetics—the scientific discussion of how ancestral experiences may affect the biology of descendants —and also of Fanon's conception of the colonised body, in which the history of violence is inscribed upon the body.

The Final Declaration: "Bharat" and "Bharati"

"If our intercourse produces a son, / name him 'Bharat'; / if a daughter, 'Bharati'."

These are the poem's most explosive lines. Several levels of meaning converge here.

On the first level, "Bharat" and "Bharati" are names of national identity, emblems of the nation. Calling the child of a Dalit woman and an upper-caste man "Bharat" exposes what the poet presents as the actual history of nation-making: the Indian nation is the product of this history of caste and sexual violence.

On the second level, the nationalist image of "Mother India" imagines the mother as upper-caste and pure. Vadel suggests that the real "Mother India" is the Dalit woman, upon whose body the nation's history has been written.

On the third level, the conditional phrases "if a son" and "if a daughter" formulate a demand upon the future: acknowledge this truth.

In Annihilation of Caste, B. R. Ambedkar argues that the persistence of caste depends on endogamy, marriage within one's caste. Vadel's poem turns this argument around: annihilating caste begins not only with marriage but with acknowledging the history of caste violence.

3. Umesh Solanki: "Let the People Freeze"

Poetic Form: An Extended Metaphor of Freezing

"Let the People Freeze" rests upon a single extended metaphor, the development of one central image throughout the poem. "To freeze", a simple physical action, becomes an intricate political metaphor.

The structure is anaphoric: the repeated phrase "let it freeze" gives the poem an incantatory quality. But this incantation belongs not to devotion, but to revolution.

The Political Philosophy of "Freezing"

Solanki's desired "freezing" is not a demand for stasis against change; rather, it seeks transformation through a stoppage of ordinary motion.

"Let the tea freeze in the kettle": tea symbolises motion and heat, made and consumed daily. For it to freeze means the suspension of everyday normality.

"Let soft fingers turn into dead marine rock at the mere touch of money": money and soft fingers form a metaphor for capitalist exploitation of labour. The fingers that touch money become lifeless stone: capital petrifies the human being.

"To disperse this thick blanket of fog": fog represents ignorance, illusion and falsehood. The social confusion that makes Dalit oppression seem normal can be removed only by freezing—by a radical interruption.

Solanki's freezing enters into poetic dialogue with Marx's conception of congealed labour, according to which capital is accumulated labour appropriated by its owner. If labour "freezes", that is, if workers strike, the system sustained by their labour begins to collapse.

4. Umesh Solanki: "The Broomstick's Reproaches"

Poetic Form: Satirical Address

"The Broomstick's Reproaches" directly addresses Gandhi. This mode resembles Gauri's "Henna-Stained Hands", addressed to Krishna, and Vijayashri's "Alisamma's Curse", addressed to the oppressor.

But the address in this poem is distinctive: it directly expresses anger and disappointment towards Gandhi, presented as the "Mahatma" and supposed benefactor of Dalits.

A Poetic Representation of the Gandhi–Ambedkar Conflict

The dispute between Gandhi and Ambedkar was one of modern Indian history's most consequential political and philosophical debates. Gandhi's use of "Harijan" was associated with reforming the position of Dalits within the Hindu social order; Ambedkar rejected the foundations of that order.

Solanki brings this historical disagreement into poetry.

"Your khadi wears out very quickly": khadi symbolises Gandhi—swadeshi, simplicity and nationalism. Its wearing out exposes the hollowness of the symbol. Gandhian ideals, the poem suggests, have not proved durable in Dalit lives.

"You must certainly detest a life imprisoned in a frame on the wall": Gandhi's portrait hangs framed in government offices, schools and homes. The frame signifies institutionalisation: Gandhi is turned into a museum object, so that his actual ideas cease to affect society.

"For whom are you smiling?" This is a sharply directed question. Gandhi smiles in his portrait, but the Dalit community on whose behalf he claimed to work has little reason to smile. For whom, then, is that smile intended?

The "Broomstick's Reproaches"

The title "The Broomstick's Reproaches" has several meanings. The kharara, or broom, is an emblem of Gandhi's cleanliness movement. Yet the broom handle is what remains after the broom has worn away.

The poem shows those remnants—the people left behind after the cleanliness campaign: "In the hidden lanes of the city, the rubbish of broom handles— / they mutter / and groan."

This muttering and groaning gives voice to the suffering of Dalit sanitation workers left outside Gandhi's programme of "cleanliness".

July 2009: Historical Context

A contextual note at the poem's end refers to the July 2009 illicit-liquor tragedy in Ahmedabad, in which, according to the text, many of those who died after drinking adulterated alcohol were Dalit labourers.

Gandhi opposed alcohol. Gujarat is a prohibition state, associated with Gandhi's ideals. Yet in this supposedly "Gandhian" state, Dalit labourers die from adulterated liquor.

"Gandhi, / I pour liquor over your head": this is an exceedingly fierce line. To pour alcohol—one of Gandhi's greatest prohibitions—over his head is an act of total repudiation.

"Damn you, / may a bag of liquor land on your skull": this is a curse, like Vijayashri's "Alisamma's Curse". Here, however, the curse is more satirical: liquor, which Gandhi rejected, is visited upon Gandhi himself.

Ambedkar's criticism of Gandhi—that Gandhi pursued politics in the name of Dalits without fundamentally changing caste structures—takes poetic form in Solanki's work.

5. Comparative Analysis: Telugu and Gujarati

Comparing these Gujarati poems with the Telugu tradition reveals important similarities and differences.

Urban orientation: Telugu Dalit poetry is often linked to rural and agricultural realities—fields, paddy, landlords. The Gujarati poems concentrate on the city—railway stations, rickshaws, toilets and advertisements. This reveals the geographical diversity of Dalit experience.

Male voices: Women poets predominated in the Telugu series. All three poets in this Gujarati selection are men. Their work brings out regional differences in the Dalit movement.

The Gandhi question: Gandhi is rarely mentioned in the Telugu poems; in the Gujarati Dalit poems, written in Gandhi's home region, the Gandhi–Ambedkar debate is central. Local history enters poetry.

Poetic language: Indigenous images (amaltas, partridge, the goddess Maisamma) abound in the Telugu poems. The Gujarati poems favour civic and modern objects—posters, advertisements and pay-and-use toilets.

6. A Special Note on the Translation Chain

These poems travelled through Gujarati → English → Maithili. There is a notable difference from the Telugu poems: the latter were translated into English by Purushottam K., whereas Hemang Desai translated the Gujarati poems into English.

Hemang Desai is himself a scholar of Gujarati Dalit literature. His work is thus an insider's translation, undertaken by a member of the culture from which the texts are translated. This allows culturally specific references, such as "khaman-khadi" and "kharara", to be translated with greater authenticity.

Conclusion

Together, these four Gujarati Dalit poems offer a comprehensive picture of Dalit urban experience.

Garange's "Poster": a poem of the invisibility and distorted visibility of Dalit existence.

Vadel's "Sexual Intercourse": a poem linking the history of caste-sexual violence to nation-making.

Solanki's "Let the People Freeze": a poem of radical stoppage, strike and the paralysis of a system.

Solanki's "The Broomstick's Reproaches": a poem of the contradiction between Gandhianism and Dalit reality.

Together, the four poems become a poetic manifesto: the modern Indian state —its symbols (Gandhi, the national flag and the Constitution) and institutions (police, courts and media)—has failed to secure justice for Dalit existence.

As long as that failure continues, Dalit poetry—in Telugu, Gujarati and Maithili—will go on questioning, bearing witness and pronouncing its curses.

Odia Dalit Poetry by Basudev Sunani; translated from Odia into English by Sailen Routray; from English into Maithili by Gajendra Thakur.

Odia Dalit Poetry: A Critical Study of Two Poems by Basudev Sunani

"There Is Still Much Left to Happen", "Address", and "Sadananda"

Preliminary Observations

Basudev Sunani is a distinctive and complex voice in Odia Dalit poetry. Unlike the Telugu and Gujarati poems, whose central modes were often direct political declaration or testimony to individual suffering, Sunani's poetry expresses Dalit experience through mystical and philosophical dimensions. His poetic language is densely metaphorical: drops, seeds, fish, egrets and the sea become images of nature and the cosmos through which the invisibility and struggle of Dalit identity are articulated.

The collection contains three related poetic sections—"There Is Still Much Left to Happen", "Address", and "Sadananda". Together, they offer a three-dimensional argument: the warning of existence, the invisibility of existence, and the innocence and irony of existence.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

"There Is Still Much Left to Happen"

Two refrain lines recur in this poem: "And yet I do not know why I feel / that only at the corner / something remains hanging, swaying." They appear at the beginning and again in the middle. Their recurrence creates a sustained feeling of uncertainty, as though something were unfinished, as though an explosion were still to come.

The structure is built upon contrasting pairs: "the sound of a bell" versus "the explosion of a drum"; "gathering sticks and leaves" versus "the destruction of a house"; "Panchajanya" versus "the smallest response". These pairs reveal the tension between the two poles of Dalit identity: invisibility and eruption.

"Address"

This poem is structured as a fragmented self-portrait. "I am still here …" occurs three times, in three distinct forms.

First, an elderly woman carrying lights in a wedding procession. Second, a sick old man begging before a temple. Third, a sleeping child lying in the cold on a platform.

These are three generations of Dalit existence—old woman, grown man and child—all living within the same invisibility.

"And yet you want my address! / How strange!" This astonished irony—the poet is surprised that someone asks for an address when his existence is everywhere—is the emotional centre of the entire poem.

"Sadananda"

The structure of this poem is a dramatic monologue: an actual person, Sadananda, who has come to receive a prize at a farmers' fair, sees the sea. This straightforward realist arrangement differs from the preceding two poems.

Yet a profound political question lies within this simplicity: "Why should there not be drought in my region / when all the water is held hostage by the sea?"

2. "Panchajanya" and "Vajra": Dalit Uses of Mythological Metaphor

"I know that no voice here / is less than 'Panchajanya'. / The smallest response / roars like a thunderbolt."

Panchajanya, Krishna's conch, announces the beginning of the Mahabharata war. The image compares the Dalit voice with Krishna's conch.

Working in the broad tradition of Bhimanna's counter-reading of mythology —his re-reading of the Mahabharata's characters from a Dalit standpoint—

Sunani does something different. He does not oppose the mythological symbol; he borrows it and declares that the Dalit voice is no less than that sacred sound.

This is a strategy of reclamation. Bhimanna says that the history of the Puranas has been written falsely. Sunani says that our voice is equal to the highest symbol of that same mythology.

3. Drop, Seed and Pregnant Woman: Three Metaphors of Hope

Three images of hope come together in the final section of "There Is Still Much Left to Happen".

"Here in the sky is a drop / that shines despite its indistinctness, / and, dreaming a sweet dream of a rainbow again and again, / has resolved to colour the immense sky."

"Here a seed has pledged to sprout, / wishing to make everything green."

"And here, in sorrow, / an abandoned pregnant woman / searches for a moment of peace— / in order to give birth to a child / who could confront and restrain seven warriors."

These three images form a succession of increasing power: drop → seed → mother of a warrior.

The drop is the smallest and least distinct. Yet it dreams of a rainbow: the aspiration towards immensity within littleness.

The seed is greater than the drop. It pledges to germinate: not a passive desire, but an active commitment.

The pregnant woman is the most powerful figure. She is "abandoned", rejected by society, yet awaits the birth of a child who will "confront seven warriors".

In this abandoned pregnant woman the voices of the Telugu women poets reverberate—Subhadra's "Avva", Swaroopa Rani's "Hands Turned to Earth". But Sunani makes her the mother of a future revolution.

4. "Address": The Paradox of Invisibility and Omnipresence

The central paradox of "Address" is that Dalit existence is present everywhere and yet remains invisible.

"From beginning to end / my presence / spreads like a flickering line of ants / and resounds like the clang of cymbals."

The "line of ants" is tiny, seemingly endless and industrious, yet no one notices it. The "clang of cymbals" is audible, yet no one hears it.

"To find my address / you need no longer send a parcel / addressed 'care of' the sun or the moon."

The line is intensely satirical. Society seeks the Dalit in the wrong places: in the sun and moon—that is, in abstract, philosophical or spiritual locations—while the Dalit lives "in that same dark alley", a concrete, physical, everyday place.

The argument recalls Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's discussion of subaltern invisibility: intellectuals seek the subaltern in places where the subaltern is not. This theoretical question assumes poetic form here.

"If you can, / then please send me / beautiful dreams filled with sunshine."

This request reverses the situation. The Dalit does not supply an address, but asks for dreams. The satire is that the very society which demands an address from Dalits offers them no dreams.

5. The Fish Metaphor: On the Brink of Extinction

"I swim like a small fish laden with dreams / in a mere handful of water / in a disappearing pond."

The image joins ecological destruction and social destruction. The pond is disappearing, evoking India's agricultural and water crises. The fish—associated with the traditional livelihood of several Dalit communities—survives in "a handful of water".

The "fish laden with dreams" is at once beautiful and tragic. It continues to dream while the pond dries up.

In Solanki's "Let the People Freeze", freezing demanded change. Sunani's "disappearing pond" shows the consequence when change fails to occur.

"Should I jump into the sea to grant it nectar, / or dig deep and push the tender head of Vasuki, / the serpent holding the world in balance?"

This is a mythological dilemma. Vasuki, the serpent used as a rope in the churning of the ocean, sustains the balance of the world. The Dalit speaker asks: should I offer nectar to the system—that is, contribute to it—or shake the system by pushing Vasuki?

It is the philosophical problem of revolution versus cooperation, a fundamental question within Dalit political thought.

6. "Sadananda": Narrative Poetry and the Farmer's Perspective

"Sadananda" sounds altogether different from the preceding poems. In the earlier two, the poetic "I" represented an abstract, collective Dalit consciousness. Here stands a particular person, complete with a name, village and reason for travelling.

"My name is Sadananda. / My village is Nagaon. / I have come to Bhubaneswar for a farmers' fair, / to receive the Governor's prize for the largest okra."

This self-introduction is extremely simple and profoundly significant. Dalit characters in literature are often anonymous or collective. Giving Sadananda a name, a village and an achievement is a politics of personhood.

"The largest okra" may seem comical, but it contains a deep irony. A farmer who works all year in the fields receives, as his highest distinction, a prize for "the largest okra". This both devalues agricultural labour and depicts the farmer's unassuming simplicity.

The Irony of the Sea Scene

"On seeing the sea you said / that I did not understand— / indeed, that I misunderstood— / the waves."

Sadananda sees the sea for the first time. The urban intellectual, addressed as "you", says that he does not understand. Sadananda concedes: "Perhaps / I misunderstood."

Yet by the end of the poem, this "misunderstanding" becomes a revelation of truth.

"Why should there not be drought in my region / when all the water is held hostage by the sea?"

Sadananda has "misunderstood" the sea, but his "misunderstanding" contains a political truth that the intellectual fails to see. The sea, acclaimed for its grandeur and vastness, is in fact imagined as holding the farmer's water hostage.

This epistemological reversal, in which the "uneducated" farmer's vision proves sharper than the "educated" intellectual's, is crucial. It recalls Ganesh Devy's argument in After Amnesia that oral and folk knowledge can surpass book-derived knowledge.

7. "Bitten by an Egret": Playfulness and Interruption

"But while I am absorbed in playfulness, / at the most inauspicious moment, / an egret bites me."

The egret is a predator that eats fish. In the context of the fish metaphor, where the fish stands for Dalit existence, being "bitten by an egret" means destruction at the hands of the system.

"Absorbed in playfulness" is ironic: just as the Dalit individual experiences a moment of freedom and joy, the blow arrives.

This image conveys a poetic truth about the insecurity of Dalit life: happiness is always provisional, disaster always sudden.

8. Comparative Analysis: Odia and Telugu–Gujarati

Mysticism versus realism: Telugu Dalit poetry, especially that of Subhadra and Shashinirmala, is sharply realist—concrete and sensuously immediate. Sunani's work is filled with mystical images of nature—drops, seeds, fish and rainbows—reflecting the Odia poetic tradition's long history of natural imagery.

Optimism versus pessimism: Gujarati poetry, notably Solanki's "Let the People Freeze", contains revolutionary exhortation. Sunani's poems carry hope and doubt simultaneously: the drop imagines a rainbow while the pond dries up.

Individuality versus collectivity: "Sadananda" introduces a particular person, unlike the frequently anonymous collective "I" of the Telugu and Gujarati poems. This indicates Odia poetry's commitment to the preservation of individual personhood.

Intellectual versus farmer: "Sadananda" stages a dialogue between "you" (the urban intellectual) and "I" (the farmer), absent from the Telugu–Gujarati poems. Sunani brings this disagreement across classes within Dalit discourse into poetry.

9. A Special Note on the Translation Chain

The Odia-to-English translation by Sailen Routray preserves certain distinctive features of Odia poetic tradition. Mythological terms such as "Panchajanya" and "Vasuki Naga" have appropriately been transliterated rather than translated.

In Gajendra Thakur's Maithili rendition, expressions such as "the flickering line of ants" and "the clang of cymbals" partly preserve the music of the Odia original through imagery natural to Maithili.

Conclusion

These three poetic sections by Basudev Sunani—"There Is Still Much Left to Happen", "Address" and "Sadananda"—represent a distinctive philosophical and poetic tradition within Odia Dalit verse.

The first section offers a warning: something remains to happen; an explosion is approaching.

The second gives testimony: I am everywhere yet invisible; my address is in a "dark alley".

The third offers irony: Sadananda "misunderstands", but his misunderstanding contains a truth invisible to the intellectual.

Together they propose a complete philosophy of Dalit existence: we are present (testimony); we shall bring change (warning); and we see truth from our own position (the exposure of irony).

The closing lines—"Because I still live in that same dark alley / where I have always lived. / Always."—are among the quietest and most powerful last words in this collection, and perhaps in the entire field of Indian Dalit poetry.

"Always": one word bears the full weight of history, the present and invisibility.

Dalit Short Fiction: Critical Studies of Two Telugu Stories

Kolakaluri Enoch's "The Crow" and Vinodini's "Black Ink"

Preliminary Observations

So far, this series of critical studies has examined poetry. We now turn to two short stories, "The Crow" and "Black Ink". Both represent the prose tradition of Dalit literature and demonstrate a narrative medium's distinctive power, different from that of verse.

The stories present a revealing contrast: "The Crow" concerns external realities—community, ritual and relations of power—whereas "Black Ink"

concerns internal realities—personal relationships, child psychology and the sudden manifestation of caste. Together they illuminate the outer and inner dimensions of Dalit experience.

1. "The Crow": Narrative Structure and Technique

Narrative Perspective

The story employs a third-person omniscient narrator, but its omniscience is selective. The narrator knows Avva's state of mind, Bandodu's history and the crows' behaviour, yet never delivers a verdict. Such neutral narration produces a particular effect: readers must arrive at their own judgments.

Chronology and the Release of Information

The story begins in medias res: the crows are already cawing, and Bandodu is already at work. Background information—his caste, his rituals and the misfortunes of his family—emerges gradually and without announcement during the narrative.

This technique of delayed revelation first draws readers into the immediate surface of the story—the commotion of the crows and Bandodu's presence—and then gradually uncovers its social complexity.

The Story's Three-Level Structure

First level, event: crows caw, a hut is surrounded, and Bandodu asks for food.

Second level, social explanation: Bandodu's caste, his practices, his relationship with the crows and the Madiga community's response.

Third level, philosophical question: are liberation and curse the same thing? Are Bandodu and the crows enemies or family?

2. "The Crow": Bandodu, a Singular Literary Character

Bandodu is a distinctive character in Telugu Dalit literature, perhaps even in Indian literature as a whole. He occupies the lowest position among Dalits, belonging to a tenth sub-caste and surviving solely by begging from the Madigas.

The Paradox of Character

Bandodu is powerless—a beggar at the bottom of the caste hierarchy. Yet he is also powerful: "stronger than a stubborn king", controlling the crows and holding an entire community hostage.

Where does this contradictory power originate? The story suggests that his sole expertise—killing crows—gives him an exceptional authority in a society where no one else destroys them.

This characterisation evokes Michel Foucault's account of power: power does not always descend from above, but also resides at local sites of specialised knowledge. Bandodu's authority comes not from his caste, but from his unique knowledge.

Bandodu and the Politics of the "Abject"

"Nowhere in the world can one find a beggar as loathsome as Bandodu." Here the narrator presents society's judgment. Yet that same society is afraid of him.

Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection is particularly relevant. Bandodu is society's abject outcast, but the very things considered repulsive also make him indispensable. His monopoly over what is regarded as abject—crow flesh, vomit and foul odours—gives him a peculiar power.

3. "The Crow": The Crow as a Multilayered Metaphor

The crow is not merely a bird in this narrative: it is a metaphor with several layers.

Crows and Society

In Indian folk traditions the crow signifies ancestral spirits, an omen of misfortune and collective memory. In this story the crows institute a form of collective justice more direct and immediate than the human justice system.

When Bandodu is denied food, the crows retaliate. It is spontaneous justice, requiring neither court nor written law.

The Relationship between Crows and Bandodu

The story's most philosophical question is: "Are the crows and Bandodu enemies? Or are they one another's family, their own people?"

There is no simple answer. Bandodu kills crows, but the crows caw in his support. Both inhabit the same social margins; society regards both as useless, and both live in a similar invisibility. The narrative's central argument lies in this solidarity of the marginalised.

4. "The Crow": "Salvation Is Only a Curse"—The Central Paradox

The philosophical climax of the story declares:

"Bandodu will never again come to beg at that house. This is salvation. Salvation is only a curse. From then on it will be a house where no crows perch; a house where Bandodu never begs. It is an insult. An excommunication!"

This paradox expresses one of the profoundest insights into Dalit social reality.

Bandodu's absence means liberation: freedom from the burden of feeding him.

Bandodu's absence also means a curse: the house's social and ritual death.

The crows' absence means liberation: freedom from their attacks.

The crows' absence also means a curse: the house is disgraced and excluded.

This equation, liberation = curse, exposes a cruel truth of the caste-bound social order: within it, emancipation and bondage become the same thing. Whoever leaves is ostracised; whoever remains is exploited. There is no third possibility.

In Vijayashri's "Alisamma's Curse", the curse is directed towards transforming the oppressor into a human being. In Enoch's story, liberation itself is a curse. Together, these works express the contradictory reality of Dalit experience.

5. "The Crow": Poverty and Moral Complexity

A crucial dimension of the story is that Avva's family is not simply an oppressor: it is helpless.

"It made no difference whether she listened to Bandodu's plea or not. She could do nothing."

This is the moral complexity of poverty. The story shows Bandodu as a victim without making Avva's family into villains. Both are victims of the system, although the degree and form of their victimhood differ.

The presentation of this moral complexity is among Enoch's greatest achievements as a storyteller. Dalit literature can sometimes offer a simple binary of victim and oppressor; Enoch goes beyond it to portray multiple levels of oppression.

6. "Black Ink": Narrative Structure and Technique

First-Person Narration

"Black Ink" is told in the first person, by a Dalit Christian woman. Its narrative perspective differs fundamentally from that of "The Crow". Here, the inwardness of experience—events as they are felt—is the story's centre.

Delayed Revelation

The structural surprise is that most of the story unfolds as an innocent and delightful episode involving a young visitor. Suddenly, in its final third, caste enters the scene and destroys the earlier happiness in an instant.

This strategy of delayed disclosure is extremely effective. Had the story been presented from the start as a caste conflict, readers would have been psychologically prepared. Because everything appears beautiful and innocent, the sudden emergence of caste wounds readers with something of the same pain experienced by the narrator.

Two Registers of Language

The story employs two linguistic registers simultaneously.

The first is poetic and metaphorical, used to portray the child: "a frock woven from butterfly wings", "a caravan of smiles", "a petal bathed in moonlight", "the radiance of a rainbow".

The second is stark realism, appearing after the question of caste: "Are you a Harijan?" and "I have no Harijan friends."

This division of language mirrors the thematic division: before caste is revealed, there is beauty, innocence and human connection; once caste emerges, the beauty of language is destroyed.

7. "Black Ink": Shriya, a Complex Child Character

Shriya is the story's most complex literary achievement. She is, at once:

Innocent—kind to animals, keeping a diary and helping an elderly woman.

Curious—eager to know everything, constantly asking questions.

Affectionate—naturally fond of the narrator.

Conditioned by caste—an unconscious bearer of her parents' prejudices.

This complexity offers an extraordinarily subtle portrayal of caste socialisation. Shriya does not consciously practise caste discrimination: she has been taught it. Her parents' admission that they have "no Harijan friends" has become natural to her.

Jean Piaget's account of child development, in which children learn social rules through imitation as well as reasoning, is invoked here. Shriya imitates her parents' caste behaviour without recognising its ethical implications.

Through this character Vinodini raises a difficult question: where is the caste order reproduced? In the parents' explicit teaching, but still more in their silent conduct, which the child absorbs as normal.

8. "Black Ink": The Metaphor of Black Ink

The metaphor of the title is defined within the story.

"I write about those I like most in blue ink; I write about those I dislike in black ink."

Shriya's blue ink signifies love and affection.

Shriya's black ink signifies hatred and dislike.

At the story's end, the Dalit Christian narrator will be written about in "black ink". That is the metaphor's explosive reversal.

But there is another layer: "black" evokes the colour of the Dalit body, which society has long associated with negativity. Shriya's black ink, the negative connotations of blackness and the convergence of colour with caste intersect.

An Indian caste-inflected version of the argument in Frantz Fanon's Black Skin, White Masks emerges here: the colonised Black person learns to perceive their own blackness negatively through the coloniser's gaze.

9. "Black Ink": Mahima—the Presence of an Absent Character

One absent character, Mahima, is profoundly important.

"Once I ate snacks served by my friend Mahima's mother at her home. I wrote about that in black ink."

Mahima is a "Harijan", as Shriya herself says. Eating at her home is deemed worthy of black ink.

Yet Shriya is friends with Mahima; only eating in her home is forbidden. This reveals a fine division in caste conduct: personal contact may be possible, while sharing food, one of caste's deepest taboos, remains impossible.

Ambedkar argued in Annihilation of Caste that rules governing commensality and marriage—the sharing of bread and the making of marital ties—are among the caste order's strongest supports. Shriya's behaviour reveals the rule about food operating within a child's mind.

10. "Black Ink": The Final Image—Butterfly and Caterpillar

The story's concluding sentence reads:

"All the dried butterflies in the room turned into caterpillars crawling over me."

This metaphorical transformation is the poetic essence of the entire narrative.

At the beginning, Shriya is a butterfly—beautiful, free and capable of flight. By the end she becomes a caterpillar, crawling upon the ground, seemingly ugly and earthbound.

The "dried butterfly" symbolises beauty that has died. What seemed alive was in fact already dead.

The image distils the story's entire argument: the innocence of childhood that seems a butterfly is actually a caterpillar of caste conditioning. What looked like the beauty of a smile concealed caste hatred; what seemed like freedom of flight was privilege.

The use of a stream-of-consciousness technique associated with Virginia Woolf—where the narrator's inward experience blends with outward events—is particularly effective in Vinodini's Indian Dalit context.

11. Comparing the Stories: Two Narrative Perspectives

Similarities of Subject

Both stories centre upon the caste system. In both, rituals and patterns of behaviour—giving food, sustaining friendships—draw the boundaries of caste.

Differences of Perspective

"The Crow" presents caste at the level of the community: the ritual life of an entire group.

"Black Ink" presents caste at the level of the individual: the sudden emergence of caste in a personal relationship.

Differences in the Experience of Time

"The Crow" depicts a centuries-old order. "Bandodu comes every night to ask for food from a particular family." It is a ritual of long duration.

"Black Ink" unfolds in a single day. Yet in that one day a centuries-old structure is exposed.

The Gender Dimension

"The Crow" has a male author (Enoch) and a male central character (Bandodu), but a woman (Avva) occupies the moral centre of the narrative.

"Black Ink" has a woman author (Vinodini), a woman narrator and a girl (Shriya): its narrative world is entirely woman-centred.

12. Poetry versus Story: The Specific Powers of the Medium

Reading these two stories raises an important literary question: which medium, poetry or prose, most powerfully expresses Dalit experience?

The strength of poetry lies in intensity, density and suggestion. Bhimanna's "Burning Skulls" and Gauri's "Henna-Stained Hands" make a single moment seemingly infinite.

The strength of prose lies in breadth, complexity, child psychology and details of social ritual. Shriya's gradual transformation in "Black Ink", from smile to hostility, could scarcely achieve this effect so fully in another form.

Nor could Bandodu's complex social position in "The Crow"—the Dalit among Dalits, the powerful among the powerless—be unfolded to this extent in a poem.

The media complement each other. The fullness of Dalit literature resides in both poetry and prose.

Conclusion

Kolakaluri Enoch's "The Crow" and Vinodini's "Black Ink" are two significant achievements in Telugu Dalit prose.

"The Crow" presents the complexity of an external order: liberation and curse as one, power in powerlessness, indispensability in abjection. It offers a philosophy at the level of community.

"Black Ink" presents the torment of inward experience: caste hatred beneath the covering of innocence, a caterpillar concealed within a smile. It brings the wound into the sphere of the individual.

The final questions of both stories are ultimately the same.

"The Crow": "Must such revenge be taken merely because poverty prevented someone from providing food?"

"Black Ink": "We are friends; is it necessary to know all this?"

Both questions remain unanswered, demanding responses from readers, society and history.

Until those answers come, Dalit literature—in poetry, prose, Maithili and Telugu—will continue asking its questions.

Literary Criticism: A Friend Forever (Jigiri)

A Telugu Novel by Peddinti Ashok Kumar

Preliminary Observations

"A Friend Forever" (original Telugu title: Jigiri) differs structurally from all the works examined so far in this critical series. Following poetry and short

fiction, we encounter an extract from a full-length novel, and this extract encompasses the novel's entire emotional and philosophical journey.

At its centre is an extraordinary friendship between a human being (Imam) and a bear (Shadul), which becomes a metaphor for the social and political crisis of the marginalised Kalandar community. In this sense, the novel opens a new dimension in Dalit and Adivasi literature: the focus is not caste alone, but the extinction of a caste-associated cultural way of life.

1. The Novel's Structure and Technique

Opening: Beginning in the Middle of Events

The novel opens through delayed disclosure. Its first lines—"The sun rose. The sun also set."—suggest a cosmic indifference. It makes no difference to the sun whether Imam exists. This existential opening establishes the novel's central question from the first line: does human existence have any value?

Imam and Shadul are introduced by contrast.

"Imam, a human being, who moved around his animal like an animal"; and "Shadul ... was actually not a human being but an animal ... had become a gentle creature."

This inverted introduction embodies the novel's central paradox: the human being resembles an animal, and the animal resembles a human being. In the same contrast, the dehumanisation of the Kalandar community and the humanisation of Shadul are expressed simultaneously.

The Flow of Time

The novel does not proceed chronologically. It moves through a triangle of present, past and future. In the present: Imam's absence, Bibamma and Chand waiting. In the past: the night Shadul was captured, twenty years of companionship, the conflict with Malla Reddy. In the future: the dream of land and the hope for a new life.

This nonlinear narrative sustains a continuous tension between memory and reality.

2. Character Analysis

Imam: The Tragic Hero

Imam is a classical tragic hero. His tragic flaw—if it can be called a flaw—is the boundlessness of his love. He loves Shadul so deeply that he cannot accept practical reality.

Yet it would be unjust to blame Imam. His tragedy arises not from personal weakness, but from the social and political order. Land rights, police harassment and animal-protection laws combine to confront him with an impossible choice: his friend, or his family's future.

Imam's interior monologue—"Why do you follow me with your eyes closed, Shadul, placing complete faith in me? Why don't you kill me?"—expresses

guilt and helplessness together. This self-accusation is among the novel's most moving moments.

Shadul: The Humanised Animal

Shadul is the novel's most accomplished literary creation. He is not merely an animal or merely a metaphor; he unites the two.

His emotional intelligence is depicted with remarkable subtlety: "From the tone of Imam's voice, Shadul could judge the situation." He understands Imam's happiness and sadness, fear and hope. Without words or speech, he is the family's most sensitive member.

In the final scene, "Shadul came and sat beside him, resting his head in Imam's lap." This is unguarded, unconditional love. Shadul does not know that Imam is planning to kill him, and that ignorance makes the betrayal supremely painful.

Bibamma: A Symbol of Change

Bibamma is the novel's most complex woman character. She once said Shadul "must have been my child in a previous life", yet in the end she urges her husband to abandon him.

This moral transformation does not make her a villain; it is the consequence of an instinct for survival. The dream of owning land, once unimaginable, changes her priorities.

The ethical dilemma embodied by Bibamma is among the novel's most realistic features. She is neither villain nor merely victim, but a human being making a choice about survival under impossible conditions.

Chand: The New Generation's Aspirations and Cruelty

Chand is the novel's most controversial character. On the one hand he loves Shadul and regards him as a "second father"; on the other, he plans to bury Shadul alive.

This contradiction symbolises generational change. For Chand's generation, the security of land matters more than affection for Shadul. He represents a new India seeking release from traditional bonds without seeing the price of that liberation.

A new aspect of Karl Marx's theory of alienation appears here: Chand is alienated from his cultural identity. Shadul is not simply a bear, but a living symbol of Kalandar culture. In rejecting Shadul, Chand rejects his community's history.

3. Bear Dancing: The Economics of Culture

The novel's central cultural and economic conflict is between animal-protection law and the Kalandars' livelihood.

The Paradox of the Law

India's Wildlife (Protection) Act of 1972, together with later animal-welfare restrictions, made the Kalandars' traditional occupation of dancing bears

unlawful. The moral foundation of these laws is animal welfare; an unintended consequence, as the novel presents it, is the economic destruction of the Kalandar community.

The novel presents this paradox with fairness: it neither simply endorses nor simply opposes the law. Imam loves Shadul; he is not cruel. But without Shadul he has no livelihood.

Amartya Sen's capability approach, which holds that human development involves more than income and requires the fulfilment of social and cultural capabilities, is relevant here. The Kalandars are losing their traditional skills, cultural identity and livelihoods simultaneously.

The Aesthetics of the Bear Dance

The descriptions of Shadul's performances—"the Bathukamma dance, preparing bread, riding a horse …"—serve as an archive of folk aesthetics. These acts are not mere entertainment; they contain knowledge passed down through generations.

Ganesh Devy's After Amnesia, with its argument that Indian literary criticism neglected Adivasi and folk systems of knowledge, is directly relevant. Shadul's repertoire represents a living cultural heritage on the verge of destruction.

4. A Philosophy of Friendship: The Novel's Central Idea

In Telugu, jigiri means an intimate friend, a friend of the heart. But the novel's friendship is not between two human beings: it is between a human and an animal.

The Ontology of Friendship

Albert Camus, in The Myth of Sisyphus, is invoked for the idea that solidarity between two beings sharing a destiny can create meaning in an otherwise meaningless life. Imam and Shadul's friendship exemplifies such Camus-like solidarity.

Both are society's abject outsiders. Imam is nomadic, of low caste and without formal education; Shadul is wild, supposedly unclean and dangerous. Society considers both useful but unacceptable.

"Even crows take lightly a being who has no voice": this line from "The Crow" echoes in Jigiri. Shadul cannot speak, and the absence of a voice makes him less important in the eyes of society.

The Betrayal of Friendship

The novel's most agonising moment comes when Imam offers Shadul a piece of jaggery laced with poison.

"Imam's hand trembled as he held out the jaggery. Shadul took it and began to chew. Imam watched, his eyes clouded with tears."

The scene recalls Judas's kiss, a traditional emblem of betrayal. Yet Imam does not become a betrayer freely; he makes an impossible choice under impossible circumstances.

Fyodor Dostoevsky's Crime and Punishment shows how moral guilt may become more terrible than the act of killing. Imam kills Shadul physically, but spiritually dies himself.

5. The Question of Land: Dalit and Adivasi Politics

The land title is a plot-driving object, directing the entire conflict of the narrative.

The Politics of Land

The Kalandars have historically been denied land rights because of their itinerant lives. How, the administrative reasoning goes, can people who do not live permanently on a piece of land own it? The community's existential crisis is condensed into this question.

The Mandal Revenue Officer (MRO) imposes the condition that "the bear must never be seen nearby again". Here the officer symbolises the modern Indian state. The state simultaneously offers the Kalandars land (resettlement) and destroys their identity (the abandonment of the bear). This is contradictory modernisation.

Buchchayya: Competition across Class and Caste

The episode of Buchchayya, who loses his claim to land because Imam's name is advanced, forms a significant subplot. It shows competition among marginalised groups: Kalandars and local Dalits struggle for the same limited resources.

This struggle within marginality is the novelistic counterpart of what Shashinirmala showed in Telugu Dalit poetry: Dalit men's oppression of Dalit women.

6. The Night of the Bear's Capture: A Poetics of Folk Knowledge

The account of the bear's capture, a three-way struggle between Imam, Bibamma and the she-bear, has epic qualities.

"Seeing the fire, the she-bear stepped back twice." Imam knew bears fear fire; Bibamma knew to burn dried date-palm leaves. Together they employ a body of collective indigenous knowledge.

The importance of indigenous knowledge in Telugu Dalit poetry—appearing in Subhadra's and Gauri's poems as familiarity with local plants—here becomes practical knowledge necessary for survival.

7. The Final Scene: An Aesthetics of Silence

The novel's concluding passage, Shadul's death, is written with extreme verbal economy.

"After a few moments Shadul began to stagger. He gave a low groan and collapsed. Imam remained beside him, his hand resting on Shadul's head, until the bear stopped breathing. The forest was still."

This minimalist prose is extraordinarily powerful. What remains unsaid—Imam's cries, Shadul's struggle—speaks more forcefully through silence.

Ernest Hemingway's iceberg principle, in which what prose leaves unspoken can have greater force than what it explicitly states, finds an exemplary application here.

"Imam felt that part of himself had died with Shadul." This single line leaves an indelible ache in the reader.

8. The Translation Chain: Telugu → English → Maithili

The Importance of the Translator's Note

P. Jayalakshmi's translator's note is itself an important paratext. It advances the concept of "cultural translation", which requires the transfer of cultural sensibility, not merely the substitution of words from one language to another.

Preserving "local colour"—Urdu words, Telangana proverbs and indigenous plants—is an important ethical decision in translation.

Urdu in the Maithili Text

Jigiri preserves the Urdu-inflected speech of Telangana's Muslim Kalandar community in Maithili, including "Abba", "Ammi", "Allah" and "Shadul". This has two effects.

First, the cultural and linguistic specificity of Telangana is preserved. Second, Maithili readers encounter an unfamiliar cultural universe.

This uses Lawrence Venuti's strategy of foreignisation, which retains the foreignness of the source work; it is an appropriate choice here.

9. Jigiri's Place in the Dalit Literature Series

Across this entire critical series—poetry, short fiction and now the novel—Jigiri occupies a distinctive position.

Boyi Bhimanna offers a broad, overarching perspective on Dalit history.

Subhadra offers a close, microscopic perspective on everyday labour.

Kolakaluri Enoch's "The Crow" offers an intermediate perspective on communal ritual.

Jigiri provides the most expansive narrative of all, bringing individual friendship, family conflict, community politics and state power into a single account.

In this sense, Jigiri represents the epic voice of Telugu Dalit literature.

Conclusion

Peddinti Ashok Kumar's A Friend Forever is a multilayered work of distinction that operates on several levels.

On the literary level, friendship between human and animal becomes a poetics of love, trust and betrayal.

On the social level, it preserves the cultural extinction of the Kalandar community within literary memory.

On the political level, it questions the contradiction between animal rights and human rights in a balanced manner.

On the philosophical level, it reveals the tragic reality of friendship in impossible circumstances, where love and survival are in conflict.

The novel's final truth—"The land was his, but for Imam its price was unbearable"—compresses a central question of Dalit and Adivasi literature into one sentence.

Can "development" and "rights" be purchased at the cost of killing a community's soul?

The novel leaves that question unanswered, entrusting it to readers, society and the state.

Comprehensive Review: Maithili Translations of Telugu, Gujarati and Odia Dalit Literature

The Videha Parallel Literary Movement and the Enrichment of Dalit Literature in Maithili

Preliminary Note: A Historical Project

The literature we have examined in this series of reviews—Telugu poetry (Boyi Bhimanna, J. Subhadra, Challapalli Swaroopa Rani, Darishe Shashinirmala, M. Gauri and Madduri Vijayashri); Gujarati poetry (Anish Garange, Rajendra Vadel and Umesh Solanki); Odia poetry (Basudev Sunani); Telugu short fiction (Kolakaluri Enoch and Vinodini); and a Telugu novel (Peddinti Ashok Kumar)—together constitutes a carefully conceived literary project. That project's name is Videha: Videha, Maithili's first fortnightly electronic journal, edited by Gajendra Thakur.

The purpose of this review operates at three levels: first, to evaluate the poetics of the literature under discussion; second, to analyse the cultural and political significance of this translation project; and third, to investigate the relationship between the Videha Parallel Literary Movement and the translation of Dalit literature.

Part One: Literary Evaluation

1. Poetry: Dalit Voices in Three Languages

The Telugu Poetic Tradition

Telugu Dalit poetry is the broadest and most varied component of this collection. Six poets—Bhimanna, Subhadra, Swaroopa Rani, Shashinirmala, Gauri and Vijayashri—together construct an entire poetic universe.

Bhimanna (1920–2001) is a founding elder of this tradition. His two poems, "Burning Huts" and "My Hereditary Rights", reveal two principal strategies of Dalit poetry: questioning the encircling structure of religious violence and rereading mythological history. Through repetition and anaphora, Bhimanna incorporates the Dalit oral tradition into written poetry—a distinctive achievement of poetic craft.

Subhadra, poet of labour, objects and motherhood, writes the microhistory of Dalit women's lives. In "The Hem of a Sari", an ordinary piece of cloth becomes a bed, an umbrella, a bag, a protector and a mother: a remarkable instance of an extended metaphor. Against the upper-caste feminist symbolism of Jayaprabha's "burning the sari", Subhadra's Dalit-feminist reply —"How could I survive if I set it on fire?"—marks an important moment of dialogue within feminism.

Swaroopa Rani is a poet of the transformation of individual consciousness. In "Mankenapuvvu", the sequence "when … then", repeated six times, classifies forms of oppression and is highly deliberate in its poetic construction. In

"Hands Turned to Earth", the transformation from a marigold blossom into a withered leaf embodies the physical reality of labour exploitation.

Shashinirmala is the most fierce and confrontational voice. In "It Is I Who Have Lost Everything", her direct address to an upper-caste woman—"You treated me as a subordinate and humiliated me"—gives poetic embodiment to Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersecting oppressions. In "I Am Wearing a Menstrual Cloth", the naming of historical victims—Alisamma, Muthavva and Mahadevamma—is an outstanding example of testimonial poetry.

M. Gauri's "Henna-Stained Hands" is among the highest poetic achievements of Telugu Dalit verse. Successively challenging three mythological representations of Krishna—the destroyer of illusion, the lover of cowherd girls and the flute-player—the woman leatherworker transforms her bloodstained hands into henna. The whole Dalit paradox of auspiciousness and inauspiciousness is contained in this single title. In the final image —"When my hide is washed with laburnum … it becomes a drum, resounding with pure music"—Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection undergoes a poetic refutation.

Madduri Vijayashri's "Alisamma's Curse" makes one of the boldest poetic decisions in its parallel treatment of mythology and history, bringing the mutilation of Shurpanakha's nose and Alisamma's stripping into the same line. The final curse—"I curse you all to become human"—transforms Frantz Fanon's account of the colonised and the coloniser's search for humanity into a poetic imprecation.

The Gujarati Poetic Tradition

Anish Garange's "Poster" is an excellent example of urban realism. "These posters with rough faces are like mirrors to me": this circular structure, and its negative use of Jacques Lacan's theory of the mirror stage, reveal the distorted mirror of the Dalit urban experience.

Rajendra Vadel 'Jita"s "Intercourse"—"If a son is born, name him Bharat; if a daughter, Bharati"—is a particularly explosive poetic moment, connecting the history of caste and sexual violence with nation-building.

Umesh Solanki's two poems employ different strategies. "People, Freeze" is founded upon one extended metaphor of freezing, entering into a poetic dialogue with Marx's conception of the strike. "The Rebuke of a Coarse Brush" addresses Gandhi directly and satirically, offering poetic testimony to the contradiction between Gandhism and Dalit reality, while giving poetic form to Ambedkar's critique of Gandhi.

The Odia Poetic Tradition

Basudev Sunani's three poetic sections—"Much Still Remains to Happen", "Address" and "Sadananda"—show the philosophical and mystical dimensions of Odia Dalit poetry. Drops, seeds, fish and the sea: these images drawn from nature establish a poetic terrain fundamentally different from the concrete urban realism of the Telugu and Gujarati poems.

"Sadananda", in which a farmer understood something "incorrectly" yet his "misunderstanding" contained a political truth, is an outstanding poetic example of subaltern epistemology.

2. Prose: Short Stories and the Novel

"The Crow" and "Black Ink"

The two short stories reveal different dimensions of the Dalit prose tradition.

Kolakaluri Enoch's "The Crow"—the story of Bandodu, the crows and Avva's family—explores the moral complexities of a triangular relationship of power. In the paradox "Freedom is only a curse" lies one of the deepest truths of the Dalit social order. Bandodu, at the lowest level even within the Dalit community, becomes indispensable because of his one expertise—killing crows: a narrative enactment of Michel Foucault's relationship between power and knowledge.

Vinodini's "Black Ink"—"I write what I like in blue ink, and what I dislike in black ink"—constructs a striking metaphor that organises the whole story. The child Shriya is at once innocent, affectionate and conditioned by caste, providing a remarkably subtle portrayal of caste socialisation in child psychology. The final image—"All the dried butterflies in the room became caterpillars crawling over me"—condenses the story's meaning.

"A Friend Forever" (Jigiri)

Peddinti Ashok Kumar's novel is the epic summit of the entire project.

The friendship between Imam and Shadul—between a human being and a bear—enacts Albert Camus's notion of solidarity in a Dalit-Adivasi context. Both are "abjected and excluded": Imam as a nomadic man of a marginalised caste, Shadul as a wild and supposedly impure animal. On the basis of that shared marginality, a solidarity of the margins takes shape.

"Imam's hand was trembling as he offered the jaggery": this Judas moment, a moment of betrayal, is the novel's most moving point. Dostoevsky's conception of moral guilt is embodied here: Imam kills Shadul, yet spiritually dies himself.

"The forest was silent": a superlative use of Hemingway's iceberg principle. What remains unsaid—Imam's lament, Shadul's suffering—is more eloquent in silence.

Part Two: The Videha Parallel Literary Movement and the Translation of Dalit Literature

3. Videha's Parallel Literary Movement: An Introduction

Videha (videha.co.in; ISSN 2229-547X) is Maithili's first fortnightly electronic journal, founded by Gajendra Thakur around the year 2000. The outlook of this journal and its associated Parallel Literary Movement is clearly defined:

A parallel current distinct from the established Maithili literary tradition recognised by the Sahitya Akademi, one that places folk, Dalit and women's literary voices at the centre.

The recognised mainstream literary tradition of Maithili has historically been centred on Brahmins and Kayasthas, from Vidyapati and Chanda Jha to the modern period. Only now has the parallel current initiated discussion of a non-Brahmin Vidyapati [predating Jyotirishwar]. [Appendix 2: A Critical Evaluation of Vidyapati's "Bidesiya".] Dalit voices have been negligible within the accepted literary tradition. Videha represents a conscious resistance to exclusion from that tradition.

4. The Three Pillars of the Translation Project

First Pillar: Building Linguistic Bridges

Bringing Dalit literature from Telugu, Gujarati and Odia—three distinct linguistic and cultural regions—into Maithili constitutes the building of a multidirectional linguistic bridge.

The chain of translation was often double or triple:

Telugu → English (Purushottam K., P. Jayalakshmi) → Maithili (Gajendra Thakur).

Gujarati → English (Hemang Desai) → Maithili (Gajendra Thakur).

Odia → English (Sailen Routre) → Maithili (Gajendra Thakur).

Some poetic loss in such mediated, indirect translation was inevitable. Yet the cultural and social message was conveyed successfully, for the force of an idea in Dalit literature often exceeds that of its linguistic medium.

Second Pillar: Creating Cultural Solidarity

Walter Benjamin calls the translator a "cultural ambassador". Within this project translation is not merely literary; it is an act of political solidarity.

Alisamma from Telugu literature, Garange's "rough face" from Gujarat, and Sadananda's famine from Odia literature all tell the Maithili reader that Dalit oppression is not a regional but a national problem. The lived realities of the Musahars, Dusadhs and Chamars of Mithila are not fundamentally different from the lives of Dalits in Andhra, Gujarat and Odisha.

Third Pillar: Intervention in the Established Literary Canon

The most important literary-political task of this translation project is to intervene in Maithili's established literary canon.

What Shahid Amin and Gyanendra Pandey have done in history through subaltern studies, Videha does in literature: it brings voices excluded from the established canon into the centre of literary debate.

Sahitya Akademi Award-winning works in Maithili and Dalit translations published in Videha constitute two parallel traditions within the same

language. Videha contends that acknowledging this parallelism will make Maithili literature more complete.

5. The Historical Absence of Dalit Voices in Maithili

Dalits in the Established Maithili Tradition

Dalit life is absent from Vidyapati's erotic poetry, regarded as the highest benchmark of Maithili literature: it is a poetry of upper-caste aesthetics. Yet it is present in his "Bidesiya", "Pia Deshantar". Modern Maithili writers—Harimohan Jha and Rajkamal Chaudhary—also wrote from a Brahmin-Kayastha perspective, within which Dalit reality remained peripheral.

An independent tradition of "Dalit literature" did not become established in Maithili as it did in Marathi with Namdeo Dhasal and Daya Pawar, in Telugu with Bhimanna, or in Hindi with Omprakash Valmiki.

One reason was that Dalit communities of Mithila—the Musahars, Dusadhs, Dhobis and Chamars—had historically been denied literacy. They received no real opportunity to establish a written literary tradition. Oral traditions of folk song and storytelling existed, but were never transformed into part of the officially recognised written canon.

Videha's Intervention

In confronting this historical absence, Videha adopted a two-level strategy:

Immediate strategy: translate Dalit literature from other Indian languages and introduce Maithili readers to its language, aesthetic experience and politics.

Long-term strategy: encourage the emergence of Dalit writers in Maithili who, inspired by these translations, would write in their own language out of their own experience.

Frantz Fanon argues in The Wretched of the Earth that colonised literature develops in three stages: first, imitation in the coloniser's language; second, the search for one's cultural roots; and third, the creation of a people's literature. For Maithili Dalit literature, Videha's translation project is a parallel effort belonging to that second phase, the "search for one's roots".

6. Translation Policy: Theory and Practice

Preserving Indigenous Words

The most consequential translation decision in this project was to preserve indigenous terms as they stood.

"Landa", "Avva", "Mankenapuvvu", "Alisamma", "Jigiri", "Bandodu", "Jaji" and "Ippa" were not translated into Maithili but simply transliterated. Lawrence Venuti's strategy of foreignisation, through which the foreignness of the original is retained, is applied here deliberately.

Maithili readers consequently receive two messages simultaneously: first, this culture differs from yours (foreignness); second, its reality is not

fundamentally different from yours (solidarity). This is cultural translation at its best.

Linguistic Plurality

In "Jigiri", the Urdu-inflected Telugu of Telangana—"Abba", "Ammi", "Allah", "Ta'wiz" and "Kalandar"—was retained in Urdu forms in Maithili too, preserving the narrative's linguistic texture. The choice contains an implicit political statement: the cultural and linguistic identity of the Muslim Kalandar community has an equal right to recognition within literary norms.

Glossary and Appendices

The translation of "Jigiri" includes an extensive glossary and appendices, along with the Kalandar community's social and political history. Such supporting apparatus gives the translation documentary as well as literary value.

Part Three: New Principles of Dalit Poetics

7. New Principles of Poetics Introduced into Maithili

This project has introduced several new principles of poetics into Maithili literature, fundamentally different from traditional Maithili poetics. My (Gajendra Thakur's) framework of Maithili literary criticism has made a criticism of Dalit literature possible.

A Review of Dalit Literature Translated into Maithili from the Perspective of Indian Rasa Theory

Introduction: The Question of an Encounter Between Rasa and Dalit Literature

At the centre of Indian literary theory stands the theory of rasa. From Bharata Muni to Abhinavagupta, the theory developed through an emphasis on literary relish. Rasa arises from a stable emotion (sthāyibhāva): śṛṅgāra (erotic love), hāsya (humour), karuṇa (pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder) and śānta (tranquillity). The question is: where does Dalit literature, which presents itself as a record of suffering and anger, find a place among these categories? Can the stable emotions underlying bībhatsa (revulsion) and raudra (anger) culminate in rasa? This collection of Dalit literature translated from Telugu, Gujarati and Odia into Maithili raises that question sharply. The present review will assess the works through the framework of Indian rasa theory, examine combinations of vibhāva (determinants), anubhāva (consequent expressions) and vyabhicāribhāva (transitory emotions), and ask whether these works can become an experience of aesthetic relish for the sensitive reader, the sahṛdaya.

Chapter One: The Reversal of Śṛṅgāra—Dalit Voices of Love, Separation and the Body

Classical śṛṅgāra rasa rests upon the stable emotion called rati, erotic attachment. It generates rasa in the experiences of love, union and separation alike. In Dalit literature, however, śṛṅgāra assumes a different form. J. Subhadra's poem "The Hem of a Sari" reverses traditional symbols of the female body, labour and erotic beauty.

"The hem of my sari, clinging to my hunger, hangs over my belly, like the goddess Maisamma beside the embankment."

Here the vibhāvas of śṛṅgāra—the heroine, beauty and the desire for union—give way to labour, hunger, motherhood and the odour of the body. The sari's hem, classically a symbol of ornamentation, modesty and womanhood, becomes a cloth for wiping sweat, a baby's cradle, a covering for menstrual cloth and a pad for carrying a water vessel. This is a complete transformation of the determinants. The anubhāvas of śṛṅgāra—gestures, smiles and the glance from the corner of the eye—are replaced by expressions mixing bībhatsa (disgust) and karuṇa (compassion): dust clinging to the body, damp menstrual cloth and fingers burned at the hearth.

The Dalit woman's body, then, is not the ornamented body of classical poetics, but a body of labour, livelihood and oppression. In Abhinavagupta's terms, the process of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa, or universalisation, works differently here. Classical śṛṅgāra transforms erotic attachment into a universal experience, whereas the particularity of labour and deprivation in Dalit literature resists universalisation. This refusal of universalisation poses a substantial challenge to rasa theory.

The reversal is still more evident in Challapalli Swaroopa Rani's "Mankenapuvvu" ("Red as the Silk-Cotton Flower"):

"At home, male control slaps one cheek, while in the street, caste control slaps the other."

In place of vipralambha, the separation characteristic of śṛṅgāra, there is the double presence of violence by the caste order and violence by patriarchy. The transitory emotions of bondage, endurance and anger displace the classical associations of Kāma, Rati and separation. The poem's final declaration—"I shall bloom like the mankenapuvvu!"—suggests not the union of śṛṅgāra but an intimation of vīra rasa. This heroism, however, does not belong to the classical world of patrons, kings and warriors: it arises in a Dalit woman's struggle for self-emancipation.

Chapter Two: Raudra and Vīra—The Rasa of Anger, Resistance and Identity

The most powerful voice in Dalit literature is anger. The stable emotion of classical raudra rasa is krodha, anger. According to Abhinavagupta, the vibhāvas of raudra are the causes of anger: outrage, humiliation, falsehood and injustice. Its anubhāvas include reddened eyes, knitted brows, trembling lips

and limbs, and the taking up of weapons. Its transitory emotions include agitation, ferocity, impatience, self-reproach and fear.

The full development of raudra is visible in Boyi Bhimanna's poem "My Hereditary Rights":

"Vyasa, the architect of Aryan caste identity, was himself, whatever else he may have been, a man of a low caste. Today he is a caste Hindu, while I, belonging to his caste, am a Dalit without caste—such is the Indian tradition!"

The determinants of anger here are the appropriation of Vedic greatness, exclusion and deprivation. Its consequent expressions are the digging up of a graveyard, the search for ancestral rights and a public declaration. This raudra differs from the classical sphere of slaying demons and asuras. Here the locus of anger is the Dalit community and its object is the historical wrongdoing of upper-caste Hindu society. Anger is directed not towards peace but towards justice.

A question nevertheless arises: can this anger be aesthetically relished as raudra? According to Abhinavagupta, aesthetic distance is necessary for the experience of rasa. In Dalit literature, however, that distance gives way to recognition and identification. The reader does not observe anger from afar, but experiences it from within. This complicates the very possibility of relishing raudra. Is it rasa for the sahṛdaya, or a message? Does it confer pleasure, or discomfort?

Rajendra Vadel 'Jita''s poem "Intercourse" displays a devastating combination of raudra and bībhatsa:

"My soft lips touched your lips and felt the roughness of a higher caste. When your furtive gaze met my moist eyes, the spectre of a rape in broad daylight danced before me."

The determinants of union in śṛṅgāra—soft lips, the touch of lips, moist eyes —are transformed into bībhatsa (rape and revulsion) and raudra (anger). This is a threefold confluence of śṛṅgāra, bībhatsa and raudra. Classical rasa theory acknowledges the presence of a principal rasa and subsidiary rasas in a work. Here, however, the rasas stand in mutual opposition: the conjunction of śṛṅgāra and bībhatsa is rare in classical theory. This conjunction is characteristic of Dalit literature, in which love and violence occupy the same space.

Chapter Three: Karuṇa and Bībhatsa—An Aesthetics of Suffering

The stable emotion of classical karuṇa rasa is śoka, grief. Its determinants include separation from loved ones, curses and catastrophe; its consequent expressions include tears, lamentation, fainting and bodily weakness. The stable emotion of bībhatsa rasa is jugupsā, revulsion. Its determinants include foul odours, blood, flesh, excrement and corpses.

In Dalit literature karuṇa and bībhatsa often move together. This is evident in Kolakaluri Enoch's short story "The Crow" ("Kaki"), about Bandodu, a beggar of a Madiga (leatherworking) subcaste. He kills and eats crows; the crows attack the houses of those who do not give him food. The determinants of bībhatsa in the story are crow flesh, the smell of decay, vomit and bundles of feathers. Its consequent expressions include cawing, pecking, attacks upon the eyes and pain.

Yet this experience of bībhatsa differs from the classical relish of corpses, flesh and blood. Classical bībhatsa is encountered at a distance; here there is no distance. Revulsion is part of the means of subsistence—earnings from leather, lack of food, the struggle between life and death. Why does Bandodu kill crows? Out of hunger. Bībhatsa here signifies helplessness rather than disgust.

"He is the death of crows! In fact, he looks like them. His hair is like a thicket of thorns. If a crow pecks at his head, it will get entangled there and be caught for that day's meal."

Bandodu is not himself an object of bībhatsa; he is its victim. Bībhatsa thus merges with karuṇa. The crows flee at the mere sight of him. Although he occupies the lowest rung of society, he commands power in the world of crows. This reversal—the conflict between power and helplessness—creates a meeting of karuṇa and bībhatsa.

In Vinodini's "Black Ink", karuṇa takes an even more intense form. Eight-year-old Shriya loves the neighbouring auntie who is a Harijan (Dalit); when she learns the woman's caste, the colour of her face changes:

"Are you really a Harijan? Tell me the truth!" All colour slowly drained from the child's face, leaving it grey.

The determinants of karuṇa are the loss of affection, childlike innocence and the horror of the caste order. Its consequent expressions are the change in facial colour, running away and a look of revulsion. Here karuṇa differs from the traditional grief of separation from a child. The separation is not between lovers but between friends; its cause is not divine catastrophe but the poison of caste. This karuṇa approaches raudra but does not become raudra, because of an incapacity to act against what destroys the relationship.

Chapter Four: Śānta and Adbhuta—Liberation, Wonder and Alternative Aesthetics of Resistance

The stable emotion of classical śānta rasa is nirveda (detachment), while that of adbhuta is vismaya (wonder). Their presence in Dalit literature is limited, though not entirely absent.

An intimation of adbhuta appears in the translation of Basudev Sunani's Odia poetry:

"In this sky there is a drop which shines despite being indistinct, and which, having dreamt a sweet dream of the rainbow, has vowed again and again to colour the immense sky."

This is a wonder of resistance: one drop of light among the sowers of darkness, a possibility of creation amid destruction. But it is not the wonder of beholding divine figures in classical literature. It is the wonder of hope, possibility and incompletion. The poet says, "Much still remains to happen." This adbhuta is unfinished, incomplete.

Śānta rasa is almost absent from Dalit literature. Why? The detachment (nirveda) of śānta demands renunciation of the world. Dalit literature is a struggle to obtain a place in the world: land, dignity, rights and identity. Śānta demands repose; Dalit literature belongs to struggle. An apparent exception arises only at the moment of death. At the end of the novel "A Friend Forever", when Imam gives poison to Shadul, an intimation of śānta appears:

"The forest was silent. Imam felt that a part of himself had died with Shadul."

Yet this śānta is not detachment, but grief: karuṇa so intense that it strikes against the boundary of śānta without being transformed into it.

Chapter Five: The Absence of Rasa and New Forms of Rasa

Dalit literature presents its greatest challenge to rasa theory in being a literature of deprivation: deprivation of food, clothing, shelter, respect and rights. Rasa theory is a theory of pleasure. How can pleasure arise from deprivation? This question exposes a limit of the theory.

An aesthetics of deprivation appears in Umesh Solanki's poem "People, Freeze":

"Let the tea freeze in the kettle, let the piece of betel nut turn to stone. Let the vegetables become stone and the fritters become pebbles."

Stone and pebbles are determinants of bībhatsa. Yet here disgust is the reality of existence. Deprivation reaches the point at which food itself turns to stone. This surrealism produces a new form of bībhatsa.

A different form of absence appears in Anish Garange's poem "Poster":

"These posters of rough-faced people are like mirrors to me. ... The posters of missing persons change their faces every day."

Absence here becomes presence. The missing person's poster is a mirror of the Dalit face. This is a determinant of adbhuta: the presence of absence. Yet its wonder does not generate amazement; it generates doubt. There is a face, but no identity; there is a presence, but no existence.

Conclusion: Rethinking Rasa Theory

Dalit literature poses several fundamental questions to rasa theory:

1. Is rasa only pleasure? Abhinavagupta defines rasa in terms of bliss. Dalit literature, however, is not pleasure but a record of truth. Can pain, anger,

revulsion and helplessness culminate in rasa? If rasa is pleasure, how can these experiences of non-pleasure turn into pleasure? The question calls for a reconsideration of rasa theory.

2. The limits of universalisation: Rasa theory transforms the particular into the universal. Dalit literature insists upon the particular—the particular body of a Dalit woman, the specific violence of caste, the particular hunger of a leatherworker. Can this particularity be universalised? If so, how? The question requires a re-evaluation of the process of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa.

3. The number of rasas: Classical theory recognises nine rasas (or ten, according to the account attributed here to Abhinavagupta). Dalit literature proposes new forms of rasa: the rasa of labour, of deprivation, of resistance and of identity. Can these be admitted as subsidiary rasas, as subordinate elements, or as new rasas in their own right? The question calls for an expansion of rasa theory.

4. The politics of aesthetic relish: Rasa theory rests upon the idea of the sahṛdaya, a sensitive participant capable of universalisation and aesthetic distance. Can readers of Dalit literature—Dalit or otherwise—maintain such distance? Can suffering be aesthetically relished? If it can, the ethics of that relish becomes a question. Does taking aesthetic pleasure in suffering reproduce oppression? The question brings the politics of aesthetic experience to the fore.

This collection of Maithili translations from Telugu, Gujarati and Odia Dalit literature reveals both the limitations and the possibilities of rasa theory. On one side, the works expose the inadequacy of classical categories: conventional frameworks for raudra, bībhatsa and karuṇa cannot fully explain the aesthetic experience of this literature. On the other side, they suggest the possibility of enlarging rasa theory: labour, deprivation, resistance and identity may become new stable emotions giving rise to new forms of rasa.

Ultimately, the greatest question before this literature is whether it exists for the sahṛdaya's aesthetic relish or for the awakening of the sahṛdaya. If it is relish, what is the character of that relish? If it is awakening, what is the aesthetics of that awakening? These questions remain open before Indian literary theory, and this collection raises them with particular urgency.

A sentence in the translator's note to "Friends Forever" ("Jigiri") reads: "This translation is not merely literary or linguistic; it is conscious that no culture can be separated from its language." The sentence holds true also in relation to rasa theory: no literature can be separated from its theory of aesthetic experience. Dalit literature demands a new rasa theory—one that accepts labour, deprivation, resistance and identity as stable emotions; seeks the possibilities of relish through proximity, not distance; and looks for a way to apprehend the truth of suffering rather than transform suffering into pleasure.

This collection is an important stage in the search for such a new rasa theory.

By applying the traditional framework of Indian rasa theory critically, this review has brought the distinctiveness of Dalit literature into relief. It has not imposed rasa theory dogmatically, but explored its vitality and its capacity for development. Dalit literature does not announce the end of rasa theory; it calls for its rebirth.

Redefining Rasa Theory

In traditional Maithili poetics—that is, the conventional Vidyapati tradition, not the parallel Vidyapati tradition—śṛṅgāra rasa is supreme and śānta rasa leads towards liberation. Raudra rasa, or anger, is invariably subordinate, never principal.

Dalit poetry overturns this hierarchy. The argument advanced by Sharankumar Limbale in Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature—that anger is an aesthetic category, not a fault—enters Maithili literary debate through these translations.

The anger in Bhimanna's "Burning Huts" is not rhetorical display; it is an authentic ethical feeling. That anger demands a new place in rasa theory.

The Democratisation of Poetic Subject Matter

Traditional Maithili poetry, even much of modern poetry, has restricted the subjects considered worthy of verse to love, separation, nature and philosophy. Objects associated with labour—landa, pots, the hem of a sari—have not become the centre of poetry.

Through this project, Maithili readers encounter for the first time a Dalit poetics of material objects, in which the hem of a sari, a bear's hide and a poster are as worthy of poetry as Kalidasa's cloud or Vidyapati's heroine.

A Poetics of Body Politics

In Maithili erotic poetry the body is an object of idealised, poetic beauty. In Dalit poetry it is an object of labour, pain and resistance—what Gopal Guru describes in terms of radical embodied experience. In Subhadra's "Landa", the phrase "even if my intestines come out through my mouth" introduces into Maithili verse a new language of direct bodily realism.

A Poetics of Testimony

The genre of testimony described by Shoshana Felman and Dori Laub in Testimony: Crises of Witnessing in Literature, Psychoanalysis, and History—where the sufferer transforms experience into testimony—enters Maithili for the first time through this translation project.

Subhadra bears witness, Bhimanna interrogates, and Vijayashri pronounces a curse: these are different modes of a poetics of testimony.

Part Four: Concluding Synthesis of the Review

8. Assessing the Project's Achievements

What Has Succeeded Exceptionally Well

The transmission of central ideas: Bhimanna's arguments against received mythology; Shashinirmala's threefold struggle; Solanki's satire of Gandhi; Sunani's sense that something always remains; and Imam and Shadul's friendship—all are fully present in Maithili.

The preservation of indigenous symbolism: the original force of the goddess Maisamma, the laburnum, mankenapuvvu, landa and jigiri survives in Maithili.

The transmission of emotional intensity: the Maithili reader too can experience Imam's trembling hand, Vijayashri's curse, and the change of Shriya's smiling butterflies into caterpillars.

Limitations and Incompleteness

Partial loss of phonetic beauty: Telugu, Gujarati and Odia have their own musicality, weakened as the works pass through English into Maithili. The beauty of the Odia pronunciation of “Panchajanya” and “Vasuki”, for instance, is not natural to Maithili.

The absence of women translators: Works by Subhadra, Shashinirmala, Gauri and Vinodini, centred upon women's bodily experience, might have achieved greater authenticity if translated by women.

The lack of direct translation from the original languages: Direct translation from Telugu or Gujarati into Maithili could have avoided losses caused by the intermediary language.

Limits of urban vocabulary: Maithili comes predominantly from a rural-poetic tradition. Modern urban references in the Gujarati poems—“pay-and-use toilets” and the “obscene hood of a rickshaw”—can sound discordant in Maithili.

9. A Comparative Map of Poetics

The comparative map of Dalit poetry in the three languages is as follows:

Telugu: the body, labour, history, the rereading of mythology and dialogue within feminism—the most varied tradition.

Gujarati: urban realism, criticism of Gandhi and criticism of nation-building—a political-historical tradition.

Odia: philosophical mysticism, the perspective of the farmer and subaltern epistemology—an existential-philosophical tradition.

Together they offer a three-dimensional picture of Dalit experience: from outside to inside, from history to the present, from suffering to rebellion.

10. Possible Long-Term Effects on Maithili Literature

The long-term significance of this project lies not in the translations alone but in the inspiration and standards they may establish.

The emergence of Dalit writers in Maithili: When members of Mithila's Dalit communities—Musahars, Dusadhs, Chamars and Dhobis—encounter the language, craft and politics of Dalit literature in Maithili, and understand that their own lived realities can be expressed in literature, writing from their own experience will become possible.

Resistance to the pressure of the Sahitya Akademi-recognised canon: Videha's Dalit translations present an alternative standard to the canon recognised by the Maithili Sahitya Akademi establishment. They enlarge the definition of literature considered "worthy" of canonical acceptance.

The entry of other Indian Dalit traditions into Maithili: Marathi Dalit poetry (Namdeo Dhasal and Daya Pawar), Bengali Dalit literature and Punjabi Dalit poetry could, through an expansion of the project, bring the full pan-Indian Dalit literary tradition into Maithili.

Final Conclusion: A Civilisational Project

In "The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action", Audre Lorde writes, "Poetry is not a luxury; it is a vital necessity of our existence." This is literally true of Dalit poetry.

Seen as a whole, Videha's Dalit-literature translation project works simultaneously on five levels:

Linguistic: building bridges between Telugu, Gujarati, Odia and Maithili.

Literary: introducing Dalit voices into the recognised Maithili canon, together with new principles of poetics.

Cultural: preserving the cultural memories of distinct Dalit communities—the bear dances of the Kalandars, the leatherworkers' knowledge of landa, and the hem of the Dalit woman's sari.

Political: revealing to Maithili readers the pan-Indian reality of Dalit oppression, with the message that Dalits in Mithila and Andhra share a common fate.

Historical: sowing the seeds of a Maithili Dalit literary tradition—not in Videha's translations themselves, but in the future writing in Maithili that those translations may inspire.

Basudev Sunani's words provide an apt closing voice for the whole project:

"Here a seed has vowed to germinate—with the desire to make everything green."

That seed has been sown.

The soil in which it has been sown is the soil of Mithila. The seed is one of truth, justice, human dignity and the Dalit voice.

And the tree that grows will be the tree of Maithili Dalit literature, its roots in Mithila's soil, its branches in the thought of Ambedkar and Bhimanna, and its leaves green with the energy of Videha's Parallel Literary Movement.

Appendix 1: A Theory of Criticism for Original and Translated Dalit Prose and Poetry in Maithili

Introduction: The Need for a Theory of Criticism

Literary criticism in any language requires a coherent theoretical framework. The history of Maithili literary criticism reveals the influence both of traditional Indian theories (rasa, alaṅkāra, dhvani, rīti and aucitya) and, in modern times, of Western theories (Marxism, feminism, postmodernism and postcolonial theory). Yet attempts to employ these theories in an integrated manner have remained limited, particularly in fields such as Dalit literature, women's literature and translated literature.

The purpose of the present theory of criticism is to offer a systematic framework for evaluating original and translated Maithili prose and poetry through a synthesis of Indian and Western literary theories. This theory is neither wholly Indian nor wholly Western: it is a third path, shaped through dialogue between the two. It places the distinctive qualities of Maithili literature—its language, culture and regional identity—at its centre while engaging with developments in theory across the world.

Chapter One: The Fundamental Elements of a Theory of Criticism

1.1 Reconciling the Local and the Universal

The first challenge for any theory of criticism is to respect the particularity of local, here Maithili, literature while remaining in dialogue with universal, Indian or global literary standards. The distinctive characteristics of Maithili literature are as follows:

— The identity of a regional language: Maithili is one of the thirty-nine languages of India and possesses a literary tradition extending over a thousand years, from Vidyapati to the present.

— The meeting of folk tradition and śāstra: Maithili literature bears the deep imprint of traditions such as Bidāpat Nāch, sohar, samdaunī and pagrī.

— The experience of migration: displacement and migration among Maithili speakers are central themes in Dalit literature, women's literature and translated literature.

Keeping these particularities at its centre, this theory emphasises a dialogue between the local and the universal. In other words, the evaluation of Maithili literature should draw both on Indian theories (rasa, dhvani, vakrokti) and Western theories (postcolonialism, feminism, postmodernism), but should apply them with reference to Maithili literature's local context.

1.2 The Parity and Differences of Original and Translated Literature

This theory of criticism accepts no hierarchy between original and translated literature. Both are equally important, for the following reasons:

— Literature translated into Maithili, as in the present collection of Dalit writing from Telugu, Gujarati and Odia, enlarges the scope of Maithili literature.

— Translation makes room for the voice of another within Maithili literature, an indispensable condition of the multilingual character of Indian literature.

— Nevertheless, the evaluation of translation requires criteria particular to the practice: moving beyond the old opposition between fidelity and freedom, criticism must attend to the translator's creativity.

1.3 The Distinction Between Prose and Verse

This theory recognises an explicit distinction between prose and verse:

— For verse, Indian theories of rasa, dhvani, alaṅkāra and metre are more useful, because the compression, rhythm and symbolism of poetry lend themselves to such approaches.

— For prose—short stories, novels, plays and essays—Western approaches such as Marxism, feminism and postcolonial theory are more useful, because prose depends more heavily on expansiveness, character development and sociopolitical contexts.

— This division, however, is not absolute. A critic may combine the two traditions according to his or her judgement.

Chapter Two: Applying Indian Theories

2.1 Rasa Theory

Rasa theory stands at the centre of Indian poetics. The present theory will employ it in the following ways:

(a) New forms of rasa. The classical nine rasas—śṛṅgāra (love), hāsya (laughter), karuṇa (compassion), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder) and śānta (tranquillity)—are found in Maithili literature, but their configurations differ. In Dalit literature, for instance, the bearer of raudra is not a king or warrior but the Dalit community; and the determinants of śṛṅgāra are not lovers but the labouring body.

(b) Extending the stable emotions. This theory recognises new sthāyibhāvas, or enduring emotional dispositions: labour, deprivation, resistance, identity and migration. These are distinctive experiences of Maithili literature, and they may be transformed into rasa.

(c) Reconsidering universalisation. Classical rasa theory emphasises sādhāraṇīkaraṇa, or universalisation. But Dalit, women's and migrant literatures require that particularity be respected. To address the tension between universalisation and specificity, this theory proposes the 'particular-universal': the task is not to turn a particular experience into a supposedly

universal one but to establish the universal significance of what remains particular.

2.2 Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana)

Dhvani theory gives primacy to vyaṅgya, the suggested or implied meaning. In Maithili literary criticism it can be applied as follows:

(a) Levels of meaning. From Vidyapati to the present, Maithili poetry relies heavily on implication. The critic must distinguish abhidhā (literal meaning), lakṣaṇā (secondary or figurative meaning) and vyañjanā (suggestion).

(b) Dhvani and translation. The translation of suggested meaning is one of the greatest challenges in translated literature. This theory holds that the translator should preserve such meaning wherever possible, but should accept creative translation where literal preservation cannot work.

2.3 Alaṅkāra Theory

Figures of speech—simile, metaphor, imaginative supposition and others—form an integral part of Indian aesthetics. Within this theory:

(a) The social life of figurative language. In Maithili Dalit literature, figures of speech are used not merely as ornament but as instruments of resistance. For example, the comparison with the goddess Maisamma in the poem on the hem of a sari reverses the conventions of the upper-caste Hindu goddess tradition.

(b) Folk figures. Maithili literature possesses its own tradition of folk figurative expression, including sayings, idioms and proverbs. These deserve the same critical value as classical figures of speech.

2.4 Rīti Theory (Vāmana)

Rīti theory emphasises style. In Maithili literature:

(a) Maithili's stylistic particularity. The sweetness, delicacy and fluency of the Maithili language are stylistic qualities that criticism must take into account.

(b) Style in translation. In translated literature, the balance between the style of the original and that of the target text is an important matter for criticism.

Chapter Three: Applying Western Theories

3.1 Postcolonial Theory

Postcolonial theory—associated with Edward Said, Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, Homi K. Bhabha and Dipesh Chakrabarty—is particularly useful in Maithili literary criticism, for the following reasons:

(a) Colonial language policy. Maithili has for centuries lived under the influence of languages of domination—Sanskrit, Persian, Urdu, English and Hindi. The theory therefore asks: How does Maithili literature confront this colonial pressure? What forms do resistance and accommodation take?

(b) The subaltern voice. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question, 'Can the subaltern speak?', is fundamental to the criticism of Maithili Dalit, women's and migrant literature. How are the voices of subaltern groups—Dalits, women, migrants and Adivasis—represented? Are those voices free from mediation? If not, does mediation empower them, or does it reproduce their subordination?

(b) Provincialisation. Dipesh Chakrabarty's concept of provincialisation ('provincialising Europe') is pertinent to Maithili literary criticism. Resisting the tendency to confine Maithili literature to the category of the merely 'regional', this theory seeks to establish its global significance.

3.2 Feminist Theory

Feminist theory—Virginia Woolf, Simone de Beauvoir and Judith Butler—is essential to analysing women's experience, bodies, voices and resistance in Maithili literature.

(a) Analysing women's writing. The presence of women writers in Maithili literature is increasing, as with Usha Kiran Khan, Subhadra Jha and others. How, this theory asks, does the voice of a woman writer differ from a female character created by a male writer?

(b) The politics of the body. The representation of the female body is a central issue in Maithili literature. Feminist criticism can ask whether that body is an ornament of śṛṅgāra or a record of labour; an object of desire or a site of resistance.

(c) Intersectionality, or interrelated forms of oppression. Dalit feminism, represented here by writers such as Shaila Devi and Bima Bhim, analyses the double oppression of caste and gender. This theory therefore centres intersectionality: women's experiences in Maithili literature must be understood at the intersection of caste, class, region and religion.

3.3 Marxist Theory

Marxist theory—Karl Marx, Georg Lukács and Antonio Gramsci—is useful for analysing class conflict, economic foundations and ideology in literature.

(a) Class struggle. Conflicts between landlords and peasants, workers and employers, and upper castes and Dalits are central to Maithili literature. Marxist theory analyses the economic foundation of these conflicts.

(b) Hegemony. Gramsci's concept of hegemony helps to analyse the cultural forms of upper-caste dominance in Maithili literature. The process by which Vidyapati is declared a Brahmin, for example, is an operation of hegemony.

(c) Market capitalism. Translated literature, especially translations of Dalit literature, is increasingly exposed to pressures from the market and publishing industry. Marxist criticism examines this political-economic context.

3.4 Postmodernism and Poststructuralism

Postmodernism, associated with Jean-François Lyotard, and poststructuralism, associated with Jacques Derrida and Michel Foucault, emphasise the instability of concepts such as truth, identity, authorship and history.

(a) The instability of identity. In Maithili literature, 'Maithil' identity—linguistic, cultural and regional—is not natural but constructed. Postmodern criticism examines the processes of its construction.

(b) The death of the author. Derrida's notion of the 'death of the author' is especially pertinent to criticism of translated literature. Translation blurs the boundary between the original author and the translator. This theory proposes reconsidering authorship in the context of the translation process.

(c) The fragmentation of history. Foucault's archaeology of history provides a means for critically rereading the historiography of Maithili literature. The history of the construction of Vidyapati's caste identity, for example, calls for a political analysis of historical writing.

Chapter Four: A Practical Framework for Criticism

4.1 Levels of Critical Analysis

This theory proposes five levels for analysing a literary work:

First level: Linguistic analysis

— Analysis of style, rhythm, vocabulary and grammatical particularities in Maithili.

— Analysis of similarities and differences between the source language and target language in translated writing.

Second level: Stylistic analysis

— Applying Indian theories: rīti, alaṅkāra, guṇa and doṣa.

— Applying Western theories: stylistics, narrative technique, imagery and symbolism.

Third level: Rasa-dhvani analysis

— Identifying the work's sthāyibhāva, or enduring emotional disposition.

— Analysing vibhāva, anubhāva and vyabhicāribhāva: the determinants, expressive consequences and transitory emotions.

— Identifying and analysing levels of suggested meaning.

— Evaluating the process through which rasa is realised.

Fourth level: Sociopolitical analysis

— Marxist theory: class struggle, economic foundations and ideology.

— Feminist theory: gender politics, body politics and intersectionality.

— Postcolonial theory: subaltern voices, provincialisation and the politics of translation.

Fifth level: Analysis of aesthetic reception

— The experience of savouring a work from the standpoint of the sahṛdaya, or responsive reader.

— The dialectic of distance and proximity.

— The ethics of taking aesthetic pleasure in another's suffering.

4.2 Genre-Specific Analysis

(a) For poetry:

— Analysis of metre, rhythm, end rhyme and other rhythmic patterning, with greater use of Indian theories.

— Analysis of images, symbols and metaphors through Western approaches.

— Identification of levels of suggestion (dhvani).

(b) For short stories and novels:

— Narrative technique: omniscient narration, first-person narration and multiple narrators.

— Character development: round or multidimensional characters, flat or one-dimensional characters, and existential characters.

— Plot: linear, cyclical or fragmented structures and stream of consciousness.

— Temporal structure: chronology, nonchronological ordering, flashback and foreshadowing.

(c) For drama:

— Theatricality: acting, instruments, dialogue and the relationship with the audience.

— Indian dramaturgical theory: vṛtti, pravṛtti, puruṣa-prakṛti and classifications of heroes and heroines.

— Western dramatic theory: epic theatre (Brecht), theatre of the absurd (Beckett and Ionesco) and feminist theatre.

(d) For translated literature:

— Degrees of equivalence between source and target languages.

— Translating suggestion: loss or preservation of dhvani.

— Cultural translation: presenting the local within a global context.

— The translator's creativity: balancing fidelity and freedom.

4.3 Categories Specific to Maithili Literature

This theory recognises the following categories distinctive to Maithili literature:

(a) Folk literature. Bidāpat Nāch, sohar, samdaunī, pagrī, wedding songs, Chaurā-Chaurī and jhūmar call for the development of a folk aesthetics appropriate to their analysis.

(b) Dalit literature. Maithili Dalit literature is relatively new but growing rapidly. Its evaluation requires a Dalit aesthetics concerned with pain, outrage, resistance, identity and struggle.

(c) Women's literature. Feminist aesthetics is needed to examine the representation of the female body, the home and the outside world, maternity, desire and resistance in Maithili women's writing.

(d) Migrant literature. Maithili writing produced in Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and countries of migration requires a diasporic aesthetics of multiple identities, hybridity and uprooting.

Chapter Five: An Illustrative Application of the Theory

5.1 Example: A Review of the Present Anthology

The present anthology of Dalit literature translated into Maithili may be analysed at the following levels:

First level: Linguistic analysis

— How are the rhythms, vocabularies and idioms of the original Telugu, Gujarati and Odia languages represented in the Maithili translations?

— How have Urdu words present in the Telangana dialect of Telugu been localised in Maithili translation?

Second level: Stylistic analysis

— How do poetic images such as the burning skull, the hem of a sari and mankenapuvvu help to construct a Dalit aesthetics?

— What narrative techniques—realist, symbolic or allegorical—are used in the short stories 'The Crow' and 'Black Ink'?

Third level: Rasa-dhvani analysis

— Identify the enduring emotional dispositions associated with raudra, bībhatsa and karuṇa.

— Examine the reversal of śṛṅgāra, in which the labouring or deprived body is presented within an erotic-aesthetic framework.

— Examine levels of suggestion in the burning skull: Dalit identity, the politics of religion and the irony of rebirth.

Fourth level: Sociopolitical analysis

— Class struggle: the opposition of landlord and peasant, capital and labour.

— Caste politics: conflict between upper castes and Dalits, untouchability and caste violence.

— Gender politics: patriarchy, oppression of women's bodies and the double oppression of Dalit women.

— Subaltern voices: representations of marginalised groups such as the Madiga leatherworkers, Bandodu and the Kalandars who perform with bears.

Fifth level: Analysis of aesthetic reception

— The aesthetic experience of suffering: Can a reader take aesthetic pleasure in Dalit suffering? If so, what are the ethics of such an experience?

— Distance and proximity: Do Dalit and non-Dalit readers experience the work differently?

— The realisation of rasa: Is rasa realised in this literature, or does the literature collide with the limits of rasa itself?

Chapter Six: Limits and Possibilities of the Theory of Criticism

6.1 Limitations

No theory is complete. The present theory has the following limitations:

(a) The difficulty of synthesis. Indian and Western theories differ in terminology, concepts and philosophy; bringing them together inevitably creates tensions. Rather than suppress those tensions, this theory proposes to employ them creatively.

(b) The diversity of Maithili literature. From Vidyapati to the present, Maithili literature is extraordinarily varied: epics, lyric collections, folk theatre, modern poetry, novels, short stories, Dalit writing, women's writing and diasporic writing. It would be improper to claim that a single theory could fully explain every genre. This theory accordingly stresses flexibility: critics should exercise judgement in applying it.

(c) The particularity of translation. Reviewing translated literature requires knowledge of both the original and the translation. Not every critic, however, is multilingual. This theory recognises the limits of translation criticism and explores the possibility of collaborative criticism.

6.2 Possibilities

(a) Interdisciplinarity. This theory connects literature to history, sociology, political science, philosophy and linguistics. Its interdisciplinary perspective opens up the possibility of multidimensional analysis of Maithili literature.

(b) Comparative literature. It opens up possibilities for comparing Maithili literature with other Indian literatures—Telugu, Gujarati, Odia, Bengali and Hindi—and with world literature.

(c) Translation studies. It establishes translation not as a secondary undertaking but as a creative literary practice, thereby offering scope for the development of translation criticism.

(d) The localisation of theory. It proposes both the adoption and the critique of Western theories: using postcolonial thought, for example, while also criticising Eurocentric tendencies.

Conclusion: The Future of a Theory of Criticism

This theory attempts to bring Indian and Western approaches into dialogue, but their synthesis is not free of contradictions. Such contradictions are a strength rather than a weakness, because they acknowledge literature's complexity instead of trying to simplify it.

Maithili literature—with its thousand-year history, the meeting of folk and learned traditions, the experience of migration and the emergence of Dalit and women's voices—needs a theory of criticism that puts the local at the centre while engaging with the global. The present theory attempts to answer that need.

It makes no claim to final truth; it is a point of departure. It opens new doors for Maithili criticism, enabling dialogue between rasa and pain, dhvani and resistance, figurative language and hybridity, tranquillity and struggle.

The critic's final observation: A theory of criticism remains alive only when it continues to evolve, ask questions and encounter new literary experience. This theory is an invitation to that development. Future criticism of Maithili literature will continue to respond to the invitation.

Appendix: A Concise Outline of the Theory of Criticism

Level of analysis	Indian theory	Western theory	Maithili specificity
Linguistic	Powers of words; grammar	Stylistics; linguistics	Maithili pronunciation; idioms
Stylistic	Rīti; figures of speech; merits and faults	Narratology; imagery; symbolism	Folk figures of speech; proverbs
Rasa and dhvani	Rasa; dhvani; suggested meaning	Phenomenology; hermeneutics	Dalit rasa; the rasa of migration
Social	—	Marxism; feminism; postcolonialism	Caste; gender; class; migration
Aesthetic reception	Sahṛdaya; cultivated responsiveness	Reception theory; reader-response criticism	Dalit and non-Dalit readers

This outline offers the critic flexibility—the freedom to select levels and theories in accordance with critical judgement.

A Theory of Criticism for Dalit Literature: A Specialised Framework for Original and Translated Dalit Prose and Poetry in Maithili, Based on Indian and Western Literary Theories

Introduction: The Particular Need for Criticism of Dalit Literature

Dalit literature is not merely a literary genre; it is a movement, a manifesto of resistance. It places pain, outrage, identity and struggle at its centre. General literary theories are therefore insufficient for its criticism. What is required is a specialised critical theory that recognises the particularity of Dalit literature, understands its politics and brings its aesthetics into dialogue with the tradition of rasa theory.

Bringing together Indian theories (rasa, dhvani, alaṅkāra, rīti and aucitya) and Western theories (Marxism, feminism, postcolonialism, Dalit movement theory and postmodernism), the present theory offers a finely adjusted framework for reviewing original and translated Dalit prose and poetry in Maithili.

Chapter One: The Distinctive Character of Dalit Literature—Theoretical Foundations

1.1 The Fundamental Elements of Dalit Aesthetics

The aesthetics of Dalit literature differs fundamentally from classical aesthetics. Classical aesthetics, with its theories of rasa, figures of speech and suggestion, is centred on the aesthetic experience of the sahṛdaya, the responsive reader. Dalit aesthetics centres the authenticity of Dalit experience. This theory recognises the following concepts specific to Dalit literature:

(a) Pain as a stable emotion. In classical rasa theory, the sthāyibhāva of karuṇa is sorrow. In Dalit literature, however, it is not simply sorrow but pain—physical, psychological, social and historical—that pervades every level. This theory recognises pain as a stable emotion and examines the possibility of its transformation into rasa.

(b) Outrage as an extension of raudra. Classical raudra, the rasa of fierce anger, has anger as its stable emotion and is conventionally located in kings and warriors, the slayers of demons. In Dalit literature the bearer of outrage is the Dalit community and its object is the caste system. This theory recognises outrage both as an extension of raudra and as a new form of it.

(c) Identity as a new form of vīra. Classical vīra has heroic energy as its stable emotion and is associated with kings, Kshatriyas and warriors. The energy of Dalit identity lies in the reconstruction and reclamation of Dalit selfhood. The present theory recognises identity as a new form of vīra.

(d) Struggle as a new form of rasa. Labour, deprivation, resistance and migration do not fit directly into the classical categories of rasa. This theory

recognises them as new enduring emotional dispositions and explores their possible aesthetic transformations: the rasas of labour, deprivation, resistance and migration.

1.2 The Sociopolitical Foundations of Dalit Literature

(a) The centrality of caste. For the criticism of Dalit literature, caste is a central analytical category. Class, gender and region are all important, but caste forms the primary structure of Dalit literature.

(b) The experience of untouchability. Untouchability is not merely social. It operates at psychological, bodily and spiritual levels and is a central element of Dalit experience. Dalit literary criticism must develop an aesthetics of untouchability.

(c) The politics of exclusion. Dalit literature documents exclusion from education, religion, society, history and literature. Its criticism must analyse the structures of that exclusion and the strategies of resistance to it.

(d) Rewriting Dalit history. Dalit literature attempts to rewrite history in opposition to upper-caste historiography, reconstructing it from a Dalit perspective. Its criticism must analyse the politics of that historiographical enterprise.

Chapter Two: Fine-Tuning Indian Theories for Dalit Literature

2.1 A Dalit Rereading of Rasa Theory

(a) A Proposal for the Rasa of Pain

In classical rasa theory, pain is only an anubhāva, an expressive consequence, of karuṇa rather than a stable emotion in its own right. Drawing on the experience of Dalit literature, this theory recognises pain as a sthāyibhāva:

— Stable emotion (sthāyibhāva): pain.

— Determinants (vibhāva): caste violence, untouchability, hunger, unemployment, migration, exploitation, humiliation and exclusion.

— Expressive consequences (anubhāva): tears, lamentation, bodily pain, silence, anger, resistance, isolation and suicide.

— Transitory emotions (vyabhicāribhāva): despair, hope, anger, fear, disgust, shame, pride and enthusiasm.

— Resultant aesthetic experience: the rasa of pain.

(b) A Proposal for the Rasa of Outrage

Classical raudra cannot completely explain the outrage expressed in Dalit literature: the conventional bearer of raudra is the king or warrior, whereas the bearer of Dalit outrage is the Dalit community. This theory therefore proposes a rasa of outrage:

— Stable emotion: outrage.

— Determinants: caste humiliation, exploitation, oppression, denial of justice and historical injustice.

— Expressive consequences: outcry, songs of resistance, movements of struggle, revolution through writing and personal testimony.

— Transitory emotions: anger, disgust, enthusiasm, courage, fear, hope and despair.

— Resultant aesthetic experience: the rasa of outrage.

(c) A Proposal for the Rasa of Identity

Classical vīra cannot fully account for the identity asserted by Dalit literature, because its conventional bearer is the Kshatriya warrior, whereas Dalit identity belongs to the Dalit renaissance. This theory proposes a rasa of identity:

— Stable emotion: identity or selfhood.

— Determinants: rediscovery of Dalit history, reinstatement of Dalit symbols and reconstruction of Dalit language.

— Expressive consequences: pride, self-confidence, courage, struggle, unity and organisation.

— Transitory emotions: enthusiasm, pride, anger, hope, despair and resolve.

— Resultant aesthetic experience: the rasa of identity.

(d) A Proposal for the Rasa of Struggle

Labour, deprivation, resistance and migration are central experiences—enduring emotional dispositions—in Dalit literature. This theory proposes a rasa of struggle:

— Stable emotion: struggle.

— Determinants: labour, deprivation, resistance, migration and the struggle for livelihood.

— Expressive consequences: work songs, songs of resistance, songs of migration, bodily exhaustion and tears shed in struggle.

— Transitory emotions: despair, hope, anger, enthusiasm, fear and courage.

— Resultant aesthetic experience: the rasa of struggle.

2.2 A Dalit Rereading of Dhvani Theory

Dhvani theory, associated with Ānandavardhana, emphasises vyaṅgya, or suggested meaning. Three levels of suggestion are particularly important in Dalit literature:

(a) The first level: literal suggestion. This concerns the distinction between a word's literal meaning and its implied significance. In 'My Hereditary Rights', for example, the digging of a graveyard literally means the exhumation of the dead, while its suggested meaning is a search for rights.

(b) The second level: mythological suggestion. Myths and historical symbols are reread from a Dalit perspective. In 'My Hereditary Rights', for example,

Vyasa, Arundhati and Matsyagandhi are reinterpreted as mythological figures through Dalit eyes.

(c) The third level: ideological suggestion. Caste, religion, politics and history are subjected to a Dalit reinterpretation. The poem 'Burning Skulls', for instance, recasts the idea of rebirth and exposes the establishment of caste violence under the cover of religion.

2.3 A Dalit Rereading of Alaṅkāra Theory

In Dalit literature figures of speech are not simply ornament: they are weapons of resistance.

(a) The figure of reversal. This is a Dalit reversal of a classical figure. In the poem about the hem of a sari, for example, the simile involving the goddess Maisamma reverses the conventional simile: the goddess, a classical ideal, is transformed into the labouring body of Dalit reality.

(b) Folk figures. Proverbs, idioms, sayings, riddles and figures drawn from folk songs must receive the same critical value as classical simile, metaphor and imaginative supposition. The phrase 'immovable as a stone beaten with jaggery' in the novel *A Friend Forever*, for example, is a folk figure.

(c) The figure of absence. Deprivation or absence itself becomes a figure of speech. In the poem 'People, Freeze', emptiness, stone and pebbles symbolise deprivation and function as figures of absence.

2.4 A Dalit Rereading of Rīti Theory

Rīti theory, associated with Vāmana, emphasises style. Dalit literature has distinctive stylistic features:

(a) The style of resistance. In contrast to classical ideals of sweetness (mādhurya) or vigour (ojas), the style of Dalit literature may be sharp, harsh, obscene and rebellious. This is a Dalit inversion of classical style.

(b) The style of witness. Dalit writing adopts the style of testimony—autobiography, narratives of experience and documentary narrative. This style erases the boundary between the personal and the collective.

(c) Folk style. Dalit writing is deeply connected to vernacular speech, folk songs, folktales and folk theatre. Its folk style constitutes a Dalit resistance to the authority of classical style.

Chapter Three: Fine-Tuning Western Theories for Dalit Literature

3.1 A Dalit Rereading of Postcolonial Theory

(a) A Dalit rereading of the subaltern. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question, 'Can the subaltern speak?', is fundamental to the criticism of Dalit literature. Dalit writing reveals the tension between the 'subaltern', a category of postcolonial theory, and the 'Dalit', a category constituted by India's caste system. Criticism must ask: Is the subaltern voice in Dalit literature free from

mediation? If it is mediated, does that mediation empower the speaker or reproduce subordination?

(b) A Dalit rereading of provincialisation. Dipesh Chakrabarty's concept of provincialising Europe is relevant to Dalit literature. Dalit writing seeks to provincialise upper-caste or Brahmanical literature, which claims universality while in fact speaking from a caste-specific location. Dalit criticism deconstructs that claim to universality.

(c) A Dalit rereading of hybridity. Homi K. Bhabha's concept of hybridity is useful for analysing the politics of identity in Dalit literature. Dalit writing occupies a hybrid space between upper-caste and Dalit cultures: neither completely assimilated into the former nor entirely liberated from its influence. Such hybridity is a source of both tension and creativity.

3.2 Applying Dalit Feminist Theory

(a) Intersectionality. Dalit feminism—as exemplified here by Shaila Devi, Bima Bhim, J. Subhadra and Vinodini—analyses the double oppression of caste and gender. Intersectionality is therefore a central critical category: the experience of a Dalit woman must be analysed at the meeting point of caste, gender, class, region and religion.

(b) The politics of the body. The body of a Dalit woman is not an ornament of classical śṛṅgāra but a document of labour. Criticism must analyse its politics: How does the body become marked by the caste system? How does it become a site of resistance?

(c) The Dalit woman's voice. This voice occupies a third space between a Dalit voice and a woman's voice, differing both from the voice of the Dalit man and from that of the upper-caste woman. Criticism must analyse the distinctiveness of this third space.

3.3 A Dalit Rereading of Marxist Theory

(a) The dialectic of class and caste. Marxist theory emphasises class struggle. Dalit literature presents class struggle in the form of caste struggle. Criticism must examine the dialogue and tension between class and caste.

(b) A Dalit rereading of hegemony. Gramsci's concept of hegemony helps to analyse the cultural forms of upper-caste or Brahmanical domination. The process of declaring Vidyapati to have been a Brahmin, for example, is a cultural operation of hegemony. Dalit literature is written in opposition to that hegemony.

(c) A Dalit critique of market capitalism. The publishing industry, market and politics of literary awards in relation to Dalit literature demand critical scrutiny. Marxist criticism asks: Is Dalit writing losing its creativity under market pressure? Do awards bring empowerment, or are they a means of co-option?

3.4 Theories of the Dalit Movement

(a) The tradition of Jyotirao Phule's *Gulamgiri*. Phule's *Gulamgiri* (1873) is a foundational text of Dalit literature. Criticism should analyse continuities and transformations from *Gulamgiri* to contemporary Dalit writing.

(b) Dr B. R. Ambedkar's intellectual tradition. Ambedkar's thinking—annihilation of caste, conversion to Buddhism and the making of the Constitution—provides an ideological foundation for Dalit literature. Criticism should examine the literary forms assumed by that intellectual tradition.

(c) The resistance literature of the Dalit Panthers. The Dalit Panthers movement of the 1970s played a fundamental role in shaping the literature of outrage. Criticism should analyse the continuities and ruptures between the Panthers and contemporary Dalit literature.

Chapter Four: A Practical Critical Framework for Dalit Literature

4.1 Levels of Dalit Literary Criticism

First level: Caste analysis

— Identify the caste structure of the work. What are the castes of its characters? How does the plot represent caste relations? How does the author's caste position shape the work's perspective?

— Analyse the aesthetics of untouchability, caste violence and caste discrimination.

Second level: Analysis of Dalit aesthetics

— Examine how pain, outrage, identity and struggle, treated as stable emotions, may culminate in rasa.

— Analyse styles of resistance, witness and folk expression.

— Analyse the figures of reversal, absence and folk expression.

Third level: Sociopolitical analysis

— Caste politics: upper-caste–Dalit conflicts, reservations, political representation and the Dalit movement.

— Class politics: landlord–peasant and capital–labour conflicts, and economic exploitation.

— Gender politics: the double oppression of Dalit women, body politics and Dalit feminism.

— The politics of migration: its economics, psychology and its bearing on identity.

Fourth level: Historical and archival analysis

— Analyse the process of rewriting Dalit history.

— Deconstruct upper-caste or Brahmanical historiography.

— Reconstruct 'silent history': reread folk history, oral history and Dalit history that are absent from written historical accounts.

Fifth level: The politics of aesthetic reception

— Do Dalit and non-Dalit readers experience aesthetic enjoyment differently?

— What are the ethics of taking aesthetic pleasure in pain? Might the aestheticisation of suffering reproduce oppression?

— How should the idea of the sahṛdaya, the empathetic reader, be redefined in the Dalit context?

4.2 Genre-Specific Analysis of Dalit Literature

(a) For Dalit poetry:

— Analyse metre and rhythm. Are traditional metres such as dohā, caupāī and sorathā used, or is the verse free?

— Analyse images and symbols. How do burning skulls, the hem of a sari, mankenapuvvu and black ink become Dalit images and symbols of resistance?

— Analyse suggestion and dhvani. How does a Dalit viewpoint emerge from the interplay of literal and implied meanings?

(b) For Dalit short stories and novels:

— Narrative technique: first-person narration and testimonial style are especially important in Dalit literature because they claim authenticity.

— Character development: analyse the psychology of Dalit characters, the representation of upper-caste characters and whether character relations reproduce or resist the caste system.

— The politics of place and time: how do village, town, forest, hut, palace and police station reflect the geography of caste hierarchy?

(c) For Dalit drama:

— Theatricality: examine the relation of Dalit drama to Bidāpat Nāch, jātrā, tamāśā and the wider traditions of folk theatre.

— Performance, music and dialogue: how do body, voice and rhythm become instruments of resistance in Dalit theatre?

— Audience relations: Dalit drama turns its audience into participants rather than merely sympathetic spectators. Analyse this relationship.

(d) For translated Dalit literature:

— Translational creativity: how is the Dalit voice of the source language established in the target language?

— Cultural translation: how are the caste system, Dalit experience and traditions of resistance localised during translation?

— The politics of Dalit translation: does translation amplify Dalit voices or distort them? Does it carry Dalit writing to a global readership, or become an instrument through which mainstream literature co-opts it?

Chapter Five: An Illustrative Application of the Theory of Dalit Literary Criticism

5.1 A Critique of the Present Anthology of Dalit Literature Translated into Maithili

First level: Caste analysis

— The anthology's central theme is the caste system: caste violence, untouchability, Dalit resistance and Dalit identity.

— The caste identities of characters: Dalit figures include Vyasa, Arundhati and Matsyagandhi in Boyi Bhimanna's poems, reinterpreted as mythological Dalits; the Dalit women labourers in J. Subhadra's poetry; Bandodu, a Madiga, in Kolakaluri Enoch's story; and Imam, a Kalandar, in Peddinti Ashok Kumar's novel.

— Upper-caste figures include landlords, Patels, the MRO, the sub-inspector, the sarpanch and the little girl Shriya, who becomes anti-Dalit.

Second level: Analysis of Dalit aesthetics

— Stable emotions: pain in J. Subhadra's 'Grinding' and 'Avva'; outrage in Boyi Bhimanna's 'My Hereditary Rights'; identity in Challapalli Swaroopa Rani's 'Mankenapuvvu'; and struggle in Kolakaluri Enoch's 'The Crow' and Peddinti Ashok Kumar's *A Friend Forever*.

— The realisation of rasa: the rasas of pain, outrage, identity and struggle.

— Styles of resistance: sharp, harsh, rebellious language; styles of witness: first-person and autobiographical narration; folk styles: proverbs, idioms and folk songs.

Third level: Sociopolitical analysis

— Caste politics: upper-caste–Dalit conflict, caste violence, untouchability and the psychology of caste hierarchy.

— Class politics: landlord–peasant and capital–labour conflicts, economic exploitation.

— Gender politics: the double oppression of Dalit women, body politics and Dalit feminist voices.

— Migration politics: the economics and psychology of migration in the novel *A Friend Forever*.

Fourth level: Historical and archival analysis

— A Dalit rereading of mythological history: Boyi Bhimanna's reinterpretation of Vyasa, Arundhati and Matsyagandhi.

— A Dalit rereading of medieval history: reconsideration of the caste system and historical documents recording Dalit resistance.

— A Dalit rereading of modern history: representations of Gandhi, Ambedkar and the Dalit movement, including the satire directed at Gandhi in the Gujarati poem 'All the Barks of the Rough Ones'.

Fifth level: Analysis of the politics of aesthetic reception

— Dalit readers: the anthology offers the aesthetic experience of identity—the literary articulation of one's own pain.

— Non-Dalit readers: the anthology offers discomfort and awakening—the opportunity to witness the pain of others.

— The ethics of experiencing pain aesthetically: the anthology does not aestheticise pain; it documents it. Such documentation makes readers witnesses to suffering, not consumers of it.

Chapter Six: The Limits and Possibilities of a Theory of Dalit Literary Criticism

6.1 Limitations

(a) The difficulty of theoretical synthesis. Indian and Western theories differ in vocabulary, philosophical assumptions and priorities. Bringing them together inevitably produces tension. This theory recommends using that tension creatively rather than suppressing it.

(b) The internal diversity of Dalit literature. Dalit literature is not uniform: poetry, short stories, novels, drama, autobiography and criticism differ in style, structure and ideas. It would be improper to claim that one theory can explain all these genres completely. This theory therefore emphasises flexibility and the critic's judgement.

(c) The particularity of translated Dalit literature. Criticism requires knowledge of both the source and target languages, yet not every critic is multilingual. This theory acknowledges the limits of translation criticism and explores collaborative criticism.

(d) Institutional constraints on Dalit criticism. Criticism is increasingly subject to pressure from academic institutions, the publishing industry and award systems. These institutional constraints raise questions about the autonomy of Dalit criticism.

6.2 Possibilities

(a) The development of Dalit aesthetics. This critical theory provides a theoretical foundation by treating pain, outrage, identity and struggle as stable emotions and exploring their possible aesthetic transformation into rasa.

(b) Interdisciplinarity. The theory connects literature with sociology, history, political science, philosophy and anthropology, opening possibilities for multidimensional analyses of Dalit writing.

(c) Comparative Dalit literary studies. The theory makes possible comparisons between Maithili Dalit literature and writing in Telugu, Gujarati, Odia, Tamil, Kannada, Marathi, Hindi and Bengali. Such comparative research will examine both the unity and diversity of Indian Dalit writing.

(d) A Dalit rereading of translation studies. This theory establishes translation not as a secondary activity but as a creative genre. Dalit translation studies will examine the movement of Dalit writing across languages.

(e) The globalisation of Dalit criticism. This theory places Dalit criticism in dialogue with international theoretical debates—postcolonial and subaltern studies, intersectionality, the politics of pain and testimonial literature.

Conclusion: The Future of Dalit Literary Criticism

Dalit literature is not merely literature: it is a movement, a manifesto of resistance. General theories are consequently insufficient for its criticism. Bringing Indian approaches—rasa, dhvani, alaṅkāra and rīti—into dialogue with Western approaches—Marxism, feminism, postcolonialism and theories of the Dalit movement—this critical theory puts the distinctiveness of Dalit literature at its centre.

It claims no final truth. It is a point of departure, opening new possibilities for Dalit literary criticism in which the rasas of pain, outrage, identity and struggle may acquire theoretical legitimacy.

Future criticism will move beyond this beginning: developing Dalit aesthetics, expanding comparative Dalit studies, strengthening Dalit translation studies and bringing Dalit criticism into international conversation.

Appendix: A Concise Outline of the Theory of Dalit Literary Criticism

Level of analysis	Indian theory (Dalit rereading)	Western theory (Dalit rereading)	Dalit specificity
Caste analysis	—	Caste politics; untouchability; caste violence	Caste of characters; author's caste; caste in the plot
Dalit aesthetics	Rasas of pain, outrage, identity and struggle	—	Figures of reversal, absence and folk expression
Sociopolitical	—	Caste, class, gender and migration politics	Intersectionality; Dalit feminism; subaltern voices
Historical and archival	—	Postcolonialism; archaeological method	Rewriting Dalit history; reconstructing silent history
Politics of reception	Sahṛdaya (Dalit rereading)	Reception theory; reader-response criticism	Dalit and non-Dalit readers; ethics of aestheticising pain

This outline gives critics the flexibility to choose and apply theories and levels of analysis according to their own judgement and the specific context of Dalit literature.

The critic's final observation: Dalit criticism does not lay claim to theoretical purity; it seeks literary authenticity. This theory is only a guide to that search. Dalit literature is alive, evolving and resisting; its criticism, too, must be alive, developing and resistant. This theory is an invitation to such resistant criticism.

Annexure 2: A Critical Evaluation of Vidyapati's Bidesiya

Viewed jointly through Western critical theory and the Indian aesthetic tradition, this Maithili dramatic text—or performance script embedded in Vidyapati's song-poems—admits of multiple approaches. The critical reading that follows brings together perspectives from postcolonial theory, feminist criticism, performance studies, comparative literature, and the Sanskrit tradition of rasa.

1. The Problem of Genre and Classification

The text proclaims itself a "parallel universe" of the Vidyapati Bidesiya tradition. The declaration immediately raises a fundamental question: is this a revival, a reconstruction, an adaptation, or something considerably more complicated? The author presents the work both as documentation —of troupes such as the Ramkhelawan Mandal—and as invention ("this imagined play is presented"). Such generic instability is not necessarily a defect. It is a productive tension that the text never quite resolves.

From a poststructuralist perspective, this undecidability reveals the impossibility of recovering an "authentic" folk tradition. The author's own framing, which observes that figures such as Salhes and Chudamal have attracted "no research," paradoxically undermines the archival authority the work simultaneously claims. In Jacques Derrida's vocabulary, the work becomes a case of *archive fever*: the restless desire to retrieve an origin that was never stable in the first place.

A formalist critic would observe that the play adopts the structure of song-drama yet lacks regular dramatic discipline. Stage directions are minimal; the relationship between its seven scenes is unclear; and Vidyapati himself enters as a character, explains meanings, and "disappears into the darkness." These devices produce something akin to a Brechtian alienation effect, for which the text offers no explicit theoretical account. Is Vidyapati a *sūtradhāra* in the Sanskrit dramatic tradition? A Brechtian narrator exposing theatrical illusion? Or a devotional presence invoking the authority of the poet-saint? The text refuses to choose. That refusal allows multiple interpretations but also generates structural inconsistency.

2. The Narrative of Migration: Postcolonial and Subaltern Readings

Its thematic centre is migration—and the woman's experience of waiting for one who has migrated. The author draws an important distinction between the Bhojpuri Bidesiya tradition, exemplified by Bhikhari Thakur, and the Maithili context. He argues that migration in Mithila is a "recent

phenomenon," whereas Bhojpuri culture has a longer and more deeply established history of labour migration.

From a postcolonial perspective, this distinction requires careful scrutiny. The author's claim that Bhojpuri literature is "less rich in quantity than Maithili" but "superior in quality" in certain domains depends on an implicit hierarchy that the work never deconstructs. Whose criteria determine "richness" and "quality"? The comparison values Bhikhari Thakur's *Bidesiya* for its "poignant form" while criticising the "ponderous" epic narratives of Maithili literature. This is a valuable insight, but it needs more rigorous theorisation. Why does Maithili literary culture privilege epic forms over folk tales? The answer lies in the sociology of literature: the Brahmanical prestige attached to Maithili as the language of pandits and the Sarnaut elite, as against the more popular and labouring-class roots of Bhojpuri literary expression.

A reading informed by Subaltern Studies would go further. The women in the play—the young woman who waits, the sister-in-law who sends the traveller back, and the mother-in-law who dies offstage—are voices within a patriarchal order which the text reproduces without sufficiently questioning it. When the young woman sings, "I am alone; my beloved is in a distant land," she enacts the *viraha* central to the rasa tradition. But does the work offer any feminist critique of that suffering, or does it merely elevate and aestheticise her waiting? A rasa-based account would emphasise *karuṇa* and *vipralambha-śṛṅgāra*. A feminist critic such as Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, however, would ask: can the subaltern woman speak here, or is she only the medium for verse composed by men and for a male poet-character who explains her experience to the audience?

3. Rasa, Devotion, and the Question of Aesthetic Distance

The work is explicitly based on Vidyapati's *Padāvalī*, which participates in both the erotic and the devotional traditions. The selection of songs from the Nepal recension of the *Padāvalī*—songs concerned with separation, absence, and a woman awaiting her lover—places the work within the aesthetics of *viraha*, which joins Sanskrit poetics to the devotional literature of northern India.

From the standpoint of Abhinavagupta's theory of *dhvani*, the suggested meaning (*vyaṅgya*) of these songs goes beyond the literal story of a woman waiting for her migrant husband. *Bidesiya* becomes a metaphor: for the soul separated from the divine; for Mithila estranged from its cultural roots; and for the Maithili language itself in an age of displacement. Yet when Vidyapati comes onstage to "explain the meaning," the text risks what the rasa tradition would regard as a basic error. Instead of allowing *vibhāva* and *anubhāva* to produce rasa through suggestion, it makes that

meaning explicit. The poet-character's explanatory intervention flattens the original songs' multiplicity of meanings.

A devotional reading may be more generous. In the bhakti traditions of northern India, the rasa of separation is itself a form of realisation. The young woman is Radha; the beloved gone abroad is Krishna; waiting is the soul's longing for union with the divine. Vidyapati's appearance as poet-saint reinforces this reading: he is not merely a commentator, but a saint for whom poetry is itself spiritual practice. The play's performance setting —a troupe named after Rama, staging devotional drama—also supports this interpretation.

Nevertheless, the work's own framing does not wholly embrace a devotional conclusion. The final statement presents the idea of the beloved in a distant land "before discerning audiences" and offers it "with deep reverence," thus maintaining a degree of critical distance. The play is neither wholly devotional theatre nor wholly secular folk drama. Its hybridity is productive, though at times unstable.

4. Intertextuality and the Anxiety of Influence

The text's relationship to Bhikhari Thakur's *Bidesiya* is its most consequential intertextual engagement. Harold Bloom's *anxiety of influence* offers a useful framework: the Maithili work struggles to establish a space distinct from its Bhojpuri predecessor, even while that predecessor inevitably shapes it.

The author claims that Maithili lacks the "fine detail" of Bhojpuri *Bidesiya*, citing Salhes and Chudamal as examples of narratives that "cross regional boundaries" but have not been adequately researched. This is a claim about the canon: that Maithili folk literature has been neglected in comparison with the Sanskritised epic tradition. The play may thus be read as an act of canonical criticism, recovering what has been marginalised.

The play's dependence on Vidyapati—one of the most canonised figures in Maithili literature—complicates this project. The author effectively uses Maithili's most prestigious literary personality to confer authority on a folk tradition that Vidyapati's own corpus may historically have helped to marginalise. This is a gesture of postcolonial recovery, but it also exposes how difficult it is to reach "the folk" without mediation through elite literary forms.

A reader-response critic would note that the text's explicit framing of its project—a long prose introduction, extensive descriptions of performance troupes, and citation of Nagendranath Gupta's edition—creates a particular reading contract. The audience is invited not merely to experience rasa without mediation, but to understand the work's making,

its archival labour, and the politics of regional literary traditions. This metatheatrical dimension is among the play's most distinctive contributions.

5. Performance Studies and the Question of the Audience

As a performance text, *Vidyapati's Bidesiya* occupies a threshold position. It is neither a complete script nor a record of a performance. Stage directions are minimal: "The poet Vidyapati enters"; "The young woman symbolically opens a shop"; "Darkness spreads." A scholar of performance studies would ask: what exactly is being documented here? A particular troupe's *līlā*? A reconstruction of a lost tradition? Or a script intended for a future performance?

The text's careful identification of the *rāga* of each song—Dhanashi, Malava, Kolar, Ghanashi—suggests musical specificity. Without notation or directions for performance, however, these remain little more than names. The playwright, or documentarian, imagines a reader already intimately familiar with these musical traditions: a reader already situated within Maithili performance culture.

This raises the problem of address: for whom is the text intended? The available English translation suggests the possibility of a further audience beyond Maithili speakers. Yet the songs within the play are not translated: the Maithili originals are supplied, and their meanings are given in Maithili prose. These layers of language and translation create, in Homi Bhabha's terminology, a "third space": neither wholly Maithili nor wholly English; neither performance alone nor documentation alone; neither exclusively folk nor exclusively classical.

6. The Politics of Literary Comparison

The author's comparative remarks on Bhojpuri and Maithili invite sociocritical attention. "Bhojpuri literature is quantitatively less rich than Maithili," the text claims, "but in certain domains it is qualitatively superior." It is a provocative claim which, if analysed, could expose deep hierarchies within the literary cultures of northern India.

Maithili has a classical literary lineage extending to Vidyapati in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, a recognised grammatical tradition, and a long history of scholarship. Bhojpuri, despite its enormous number of speakers, has historically been stigmatised as a "dialect" rather than a language; its literary traditions have been marginalised by both Hindi and Maithili elites. The author's contention that Bhojpuri is "superior" in some qualitative respects—especially the Bidesiya tradition—strategically reverses this hierarchy. It claims for Bhojpuri what has been denied to it: aesthetic sophistication, emotional depth, and cultural value.

Even so, the text does not fully theorise this reversal. It remains caught within the comparative framework it seeks to challenge. A genuinely decolonial criticism would ask: why compare at all? Why not allow each tradition its own aesthetic measures and criteria of value? Comparison risks reinstating the very hierarchies it criticises.

7. Unresolved Questions and Productive Ambiguities

The text leaves several questions unresolved, and these silences are productive for a critic:

1. Vidyapati's status. Is he a character within the play, the author of its source material, a *sūtradhāra* figure, or a devotional presence? The work's answer is "all of these," and that plurality is both a strength and a weakness.

2. The relationship between the seven scenes. The scenes seem to offer variations on a situation: a woman, a traveller, and the memory of a beloved who has gone abroad. But do they constitute narrative progression, a ritual cycle, or a series of aesthetic variations? The work does not say.

3. The politics of gender. The young woman's voice predominates in the songs, yet her agency is limited. She cannot persuade the traveller, leave herself, or address her husband directly. The text reproduces these limits without comment. Is this fidelity to the source material, or a failure of critical distance?

4. The sister-in-law's role. In the later scenes she disappears, leaving the traveller and the young woman alone. What happened to that relationship? The work's silence is suggestive but incomplete.

5. The ending. The final "dissolution" into the beloved in a distant land is ambiguous. Is it reunion with the lover? Death? The collapse of theatrical illusion? The work, perhaps deliberately, withholds interpretation.

8. Conclusion: Towards a Critical Reception

Judged by formal coherence, thematic complexity, and the productive tension between tradition and innovation, *Vidyapati's Bidesiya* is a work of considerable interest, but also of unresolved contradictions.

Its greatest strength is its liminal position: between folk and classical, Maithili and Bhojpuri, performance and text, devotion and criticism. That location allows it to stage the tensions defining modern Maithili identity: caught between a proud literary past and present economic insecurity; between Sanskritised prestige and folk vitality; between the pain of separation and the demand for political recognition.

Its greatest weakness is its insufficient theoretical development. The work knows what it wants to accomplish—to recover a tradition, honour Vidyapati, and address the contemporary experience of Maithili migration—but does not always know *how* it is accomplishing these things. Generic instability, indistinct staging, and Vidyapati's unresolved role as a character are not defects in themselves. They do, however, call for an account of the work's own procedures, which it does not supply.

A reception-oriented critic would note that the text now inhabits multiple contexts. For Maithili readers it is a document of cultural memory; for English readers, an intriguing work in translation; for scholars of Indian theatre, a case study in the challenges of archiving performance traditions. Each context of reading produces a different text.

Ultimately, *Vidyapati's Bidesiya* succeeds in what may be its most original undertaking: placing the experience of the Maithili *bidesiya*—the migrant and the woman who waits—within Mithila's most prestigious literary tradition. In doing so, it makes a claim: that the suffering of labour migration deserves the same aesthetic attention as the *viraha* of Radha and Krishna; that the folk belongs within the classical; and that the present moment of displacement calls upon the resources of a centuries-old poetic language.

Whether the work fully realises this claim remains an open question for criticism. But the claim itself—and the labour of articulating it—demands respect.

A Critical Reading of Vidyapati's Bidesiya Through Five Theoretical Perspectives

1. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak: Can the Maithili Subaltern Speak?

Spivak's foundational question—"Can the Subaltern Speak?"—interrogates the mechanisms through which marginalised subjects are represented within dominant discourses, representations always mediated by institutional and ideological structures that obstruct authentic self-expression. *Vidyapati's Bidesiya* offers a compelling case study for a Spivakian analysis precisely because it stages the crisis of representation that her work theorises.

The young woman who dominates the songs of the play appears, on the surface, to be a subaltern figure: a rural woman whose husband has migrated for work, leaving her to confront her precarious position within patriarchal and economic structures that afford her no agency. Yet her speech—the songs she sings—is not her own. They are the compositions of Vidyapati, a male poet of the fourteenth or fifteenth century, mediated

through multiple textual transmissions (the Nepal *Padāvalī* and Nagendranath Gupta's compilation), and mediated again by a contemporary playwright or documentarian who selects, arranges, and frames them. The young woman speaks, but what she says is already a quotation from elite literature authored by a man.

Spivak's criticism of the "epistemic violence" of colonialism can here be extended to internal colonialisms within Indian literary culture. The playwright's framing—his assertion that Maithili lacks the "fine detail" of Bhojpuri folk narratives—betrays an anxiety about authentic folk expression, an anxiety the play seeks to resolve by reclaiming Vidyapati's verses as a kind of primordial folk archive. But Spivak would ask: what is effaced in this act of reclamation? The real Maithili woman who has migrated, or waited for a migrant, is displaced by a literary construction: the woman separated from her beloved in Sanskritised poetics. The subaltern woman becomes the sign of something else: Maithili cultural identity, the prestige of literary tradition, and the authority of a poet-saint.

The play's final gesture—the ambiguous appearance of the beloved returning from abroad, emerging from darkness—is particularly instructive in Spivakian terms. Is this reunion? Liberation? The text leaves the matter unresolved. Spivak, however, would notice that the subaltern woman's desire is ultimately displaced onto the return of a male figure. The fulfilment of her waiting lies not in her own agency but in the lover's arrival. Her subjectivity is constituted entirely in relation to his absence and presence. She speaks, but she speaks of him, for him, towards him. Her own voice, like her desire, remains mediated.

The playwright's own position mirrors the problem Spivak identifies. As an educated, perhaps urban, perhaps male or male-identifying person who documents and frames these rural performance traditions, the playwright undertakes the very work of representation that Spivak critiques. The long prose introduction—with archival details of troupes, villages, and performance histories—functions as a claim to ethnographic authority. But does such documentation enable or obstruct subaltern speech? The young woman sings, yet her song is glossed, translated, and interpreted: first by Vidyapati as a character within the play, then by the playwright's framing, and finally by this critic. Each layer of mediation moves us farther away from any unmediated subaltern voice.

Spivak reminds us that the desire to "give the subaltern a voice" is itself a Western intellectual fantasy, a project of recovering authenticity that necessarily reproduces the very structures it seeks to dismantle. *Vidyapati's Bidesiya* cannot escape this contradiction, but it stages it with an unusual degree of self-awareness. When Vidyapati the character appears to "explain

the meanings" of the young woman's songs, the play makes a metaphor of the critic's own activity. The question is whether the play recognises that metaphor as a problem or innocently celebrates the poet's interpretive authority.

2. Dipesh Chakrabarty: Provincialising the Maithili Literary Imagination

Chakrabarty's *Provincializing Europe* argues that historicism—the European mode of writing history which assumes a universal, linear temporality—has so structured modern South Asian thought as to exclude other modes of temporal experience. Chakrabarty calls for historiography that can accommodate the "politics of gods" and other modes of existence which cannot be subsumed within secular, developmental time.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya is a rich site for applying Chakrabarty's framework because it operates within several incompatible temporalities at once. The play concerns migration, a modern economic phenomenon: the text comments that migration in Mithila is a "recent phenomenon" and that "villages have become deserted." Yet the aesthetic resources through which it represents this modern condition are drawn from Vidyapati's fourteenth-century *Padāvalī*, belonging to a premodern tradition of devotion and erotic sentiment. The young woman awaiting her migrant husband is simultaneously a contemporary Maithili woman and Radha waiting for Krishna. The work does not choose between these temporalities; it inhabits them both.

Chakrabarty would recognise this as a refusal of historicism's demand for chronological purity. The play refuses to say, "This is the premodern tradition of *viraha*; that is the modern migration narrative." Instead, it insists that the modern experience of labour migration is a form of *viraha*, that the uncertainty of the contemporary Maithili migrant is the soul's eternal longing for its beloved. This is not a metaphorical substitution but a temporal superimposition: two times existing in one place.

The text's comparison between Maithili and Bhojpuri literary traditions also invites a Chakrabartian reading. The playwright claims that the Bhojpuri Bidesiya tradition is "superior" in certain qualitative domains while Maithili remains bound to "ponderous" epic narratives. Among other things, this is a claim about literary time. The argument implies that Bhojpuri has produced a modern, responsive vernacular realism—Bhikhari Thakur's poignant songs of migrant suffering—while Maithili remains trapped within the "heavy" forms of a Sanskritised past. The project of the play, using Vidyapati to speak to the present, can be read as an attempt to provincialise the historicist assumption that only "modern" forms—

realism, the novel, secular narrative—adequately represent modern experience.

But Chakrabarty also cautions against romanticising such temporal hybridity. The play's invocation of Vidyapati's authority—the poet-saint who authenticates the Bidesiya tradition—risks reproducing the Brahmanical structures of prestige that historically marginalised folk expression. The young woman's song becomes acceptable, perhaps, because it is Vidyapati's song. The modern migrant's suffering is aesthetically legitimated because it is framed by a canonical literary tradition. Chakrabarty might ask: can there be a politics of the present that does not require the authority of the premodern sacred?

The play's performance context—a troupe named after Rama, staging devotional drama—suggests an answer. For practitioners of the Ramkhelawan Mandal, Vidyapati is not an authority summoned to legitimate modern concerns; he is a living presence within a continuing devotional practice. The distinction between "modern" and "premodern" may not exist for them in the way it does for the literate critic. Chakrabarty asks us to take this seriously. The temporality of the Ramkhelawan tradition is not historicist time but ritual time, cyclical time, the time of *līlā* or divine play. To provincialise Europe is to provincialise the historicist assumptions that oblige us to see Vidyapati's presence as an anachronism rather than as continuity.

3. A. K. Ramanujan: The Interaction of Folk and Classical Canons

Ramanujan's life's work was devoted to challenging the hierarchical opposition between "folk" and "classical" traditions in Indian literature. He demonstrated that these categories are not fixed essences but dynamic, mutually constitutive forms. The "classical" continually draws upon "folk" resources; the "folk" absorbs and transforms "classical" forms. Ramanujan's translations—*Speaking of Śiva*, *The Interior Landscape*, and *Folktales from India*—exemplify his method: treating folk traditions with the same seriousness as canonical texts, attending to their formal refinement and cultural complexity.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya is in many ways a Ramanujan-like text. It is expressly concerned with the relationship between Vidyapati—among the most canonical figures of Maithili literature—and the folk performance traditions of Bidesiya. The playwright remarks that Vidyapati's *Padāvalī*, especially the Nepal recension, contains "pure Bidesiya" verses, suggesting that the classical poet himself engaged with folk subjects and forms. The performance troupes described—the Ramkhelawan Mandal and the Ramraksha Chaudhary Natya Kala Parishad—represent the continuing

life of these verses in popular performance settings. The work refuses to separate "high" literary tradition from "low" performance tradition.

Ramanujan would be particularly interested in the play's acts of translation —not simply linguistic translation but translation among genres, registers, and social worlds. The young woman's song moves between *śṛṅgāra* and *viraha*, between the classical *rāga* system (Dhanashi, Malava, Kolar, Ghanashi) and the vernacular idiom of the stage directions. Vidyapati as a character comes to "explain the meanings," acting as a learned commentator who mediates classical text and popular reception. Yet the mediation is not one-way: after Vidyapati sings, the young woman also interprets the verses, "expanding upon their meaning." Meaning is not fixed by classical authority but emerges through dialogic performance.

Ramanujan's concept of "context-sensitive" meaning—his insistence that Indian literary forms be understood within their contexts of performance —is crucial to reading this work. The play is not a "text" in the Western sense alone, but a score for performance, a document pointing to an embodied, musical, ritual event. Its attention to *rāga*, stage directions marking entrances and exits, and interaction between characters and audience (in Scene 7, the traveller gestures towards the spectators) all indicate a performance tradition irreducible to its literary content.

Ramanujan would also notice the work's engagement with regional specificity. The playwright's meticulous documentation of troupes in Samastipur, Purnia, Supaul, and Saharsa—naming villages, panchayats, and post offices—is not mere antiquarianism. It is a claim about place: that the tradition exists in particular communities and particular locations, and that its meaning is embedded in local geography and history. This regional grounding challenges the universalising tendencies of both classical Sanskrit aesthetics and Western literary theory.

Nevertheless, Ramanujan would also notice the absences that haunt the text. The playwright laments that folk figures such as Salhes and Chudamal have received "no research," and that Maithili lacks the extensive folk narratives found in Bhojpuri. In Ramanujan's vocabulary, this reflects the canon's failure to recognise its folk sources. The classical Maithili tradition has perhaps absorbed folk materials without acknowledgement, transforming them into "ponderous" epic forms that obscure their vernacular origins. The play's effort to recover *Bidesiya* within Vidyapati's *Padāvalī* attempts to reverse this process: to show that the classical poet was also a folk poet, that within the canonical text are the voices of women, migrants, and the dispossessed.

4. Rustom Bharucha: Indian Theatre and the Politics of Performance

Bharucha's work consistently challenges the appropriation of Indian performance traditions both by Western-oriented "modern" theatre and by state-sponsored movements to revive "folk" culture. In *Theatre and the World* and *The Politics of Cultural Practice*, Bharucha argues for rigorous attention to the specific contexts, communities, and power relations within which performance traditions exist. He is sceptical of "intercultural" theatre that uproots aesthetic forms from their social foundations, and critical of the repackaging of "folk" traditions for urban, middle-class, or international audiences.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya exists precisely within the contested terrain that Bharucha maps. It documents performance traditions—the Ramkhelawan Mandal and the Ramraksha Chaudhary Natya Kala Parishad—that were historically rooted in rural Maithili communities. These troupes performed for local audiences, in village settings, as part of ritual and devotional cycles. Yet the text as it comes to us is a document, a translation, a presentation "before discerning audiences"—that is, before an audience not necessarily identical with the original rural community. In its present form, the play has been uprooted from its initial performance setting and offered to another public: Maithili readers, perhaps, but also, through translation, English-speaking scholars and students.

Bharucha would ask: what is lost in this uprooting? The stage directions in the work are minimal: "Onstage, our Bidesiya takes his leave"; "The young woman symbolically opens a shop." For someone who has never watched the Ramkhelawan Mandal perform, such directions offer only the barest indication of what the performance might have looked, sounded, or felt like. The *rāgas* are named but not notated; movements are indicated but not choreographed; audience interactions are recorded but not described. The text becomes a kind of ghost of performance, preserving certain information while losing the embodied, sensory, communal dimensions that Bharucha considers irreducible.

Bharucha would also question the framing of these traditions within a literary-critical apparatus. The extended prose introduction—its comparison of Maithili and Bhojpuri, its references to Nagendranath Gupta's edition, its placing of Vidyapati within the Bidesiya tradition—constitutes an academic frame potentially alien to the original practitioners. The play is presented as a "parallel universe" of Vidyapati's Bidesiya, a phrase suggesting a literary-intertextual relationship rather than a living tradition of performance. Bharucha would ask: for whom is this text made, and whose interests does it serve?

The play's relationship to Bhikhari Thakur's Bhojpuri Bidesiya tradition is especially important from Bharucha's perspective. The playwright remarks that Bhikhari Thakur's *Bidesiya* emerged from his own experience as a migrant in Calcutta and his performances for Bhojpuri-speaking communities. In Bharucha's vocabulary, this was community-based theatre: rooted in the lived experience of its practitioners and audiences, responsive to their needs and concerns. By contrast, the present attempt to create a Maithili Bidesiya through Vidyapati's verses is a literary construction, deriving authority from a canonical poet rather than directly from contemporary experience. Bharucha would ask whether the substitution of classical *viraha* for modern migration does justice to the specific suffering of present-day Maithili migrants, or whether it aestheticises that suffering in ways that detach it from material reality.

The work's closing gesture—"This conception of the beloved in a distant land is presented before discerning audiences. Amid the present condition of Maithili migrants (*bidesiyas*), this offering is made with deep reverence to the great poet Vidyapati"—exposes the displacement Bharucha identifies. The "condition" of migrants is acknowledged, then displaced: the dedication is not to migrants but to Vidyapati. The "discerning audience" is invited to appreciate an aesthetic conception rather than to respond to a social situation. Bharucha would insist that a genuinely political theatre could not allow this displacement; it would give material suffering priority over aesthetic framing.

5. Edward Said: Travelling Theory and the Question of Origins

Said's concept of "travelling theory" attends to how ideas, texts, and practices move among cultural and historical contexts and are necessarily transformed in the process. In "Traveling Theory" and "Traveling Theory Reconsidered," Said argues that theories lose or gain power as they travel, their meanings shaped by the contexts they enter, while the question of "origin" is always complicated by such movements. His later work on late style also offers resources for considering how traditions are received, adapted, and reanimated by later practitioners.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya is deeply concerned with origins and their complexities. The playwright traces the tradition through multiple lineages: the Ramkhelawan Mandal of Katghara, the Ramraksha Chaudhary Natya Kala Parishad of Gayaghat, and the Piya Desantar troupe of Purnia. These are claims of authenticity and origin, grounding the tradition in particular communities and locations. Yet the text also acknowledges that the Bidesiya tradition is itself itinerant. It travels from Purnia to Supaul, Saharsa, and Samastipur; it travels from Nepal (through the Nepal *Padāvalī*) to Bihar; it moves from Vidyapati's fourteenth-century court to twenty-first-century rural performances.

Said would be interested in how the work handles the Bhojpuri origins of the Bidesiya tradition. Bhikhari Thakur's *Bidesiya* is acknowledged as a predecessor, an influential text to which the Maithili play must relate even in defining itself against it. The playwright's claim that Bhojpuri is "superior" in certain qualitative domains is, in Said's terms, an acknowledgement of the power of a travelling tradition. The Maithili text cannot ignore Bhikhari Thakur. It must contend with him, assimilate him, define itself through and against him. This is the anxiety of influence, but it is also the productive dynamism of travelling theory: Bhojpuri Bidesiya travels into Maithili and compels a reconsideration of what Maithili literary tradition can accomplish.

The play's use of Vidyapati, a figure of the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, to respond to a modern Bhojpuri tradition is itself a form of travelling theory. Vidyapati's *Padāvalī* travels from its original courtly-devotional setting into a contemporary performance context of Maithili Bidesiya. The poet-saint becomes something he had never been before: a chronicler of labour migration. This is not "misreading" in any simple sense; it is creative appropriation, the reanimation of a tradition to meet new needs. Said would recognise in this the vitality of travelling theory: ideas acquire new power as they enter new contexts, even—especially—when those contexts were never anticipated by their originators.

The text's anxiety about research—its lament that figures such as Salhes and Chudamal have received "no research"—reveals a different kind of travelling theory: the movement of academic knowledge practices into folk traditions. The playwright, situated within or addressing a literate academic context, imposes the values of archival inquiry, textual criticism, and historical documentation upon performance traditions that may not have operated according to those values. Said would observe that this is not a neutral act. It transforms the very traditions it seeks to document, subjecting them to criteria such as "research" that originated elsewhere.

Finally, Said's notion of "contrapuntal reading" offers a means of understanding the work's many overlapping origins. The play is simultaneously a document of the Ramkhelawan Mandal performance tradition; a reconstruction of Vidyapati's Bidesiya verses; a response to Bhikhari Thakur's Bhojpuri *Bidesiya*; a contribution to Maithili literary culture; a performance text for future staging; and an object of academic study. These are not competing origins but coexisting ones, layered like musical lines in a contrapuntal composition. To privilege one origin over the others—to say the "real" text is the Ramkhelawan Mandal performance, or Vidyapati's verses, or the playwright's invention—would deny the work's fundamental condition as a travelling, transformed, multiply rooted cultural object.

Synthesis: Convergences and Divergences

These five theoretical perspectives, though differing in their origins and commitments, converge on several important insights about *Vidyapati's Bidesiya*:

1. The problem of mediation. Spivak, Chakrabarty, and Said all insist, in different ways, that the subaltern, the premodern, and the "original" are always already mediated. The young woman does not speak without Vidyapati; Vidyapati does not speak without performance traditions; performance traditions do not speak without documentation. The work is itself a meditation on mediation.

2. The politics of recovery. Both Ramanujan and Bharucha question projects of "recovering" folk traditions through classical frameworks. For Ramanujan, the classical and the folk are already interconnected; for Bharucha, recovery can be a form of appropriation. The work's attempt to claim Vidyapati for the Bidesiya tradition is at once a radical democratisation of the canon and a potential erasure of the specificity of folk practice.

3. Temporality and history. Chakrabarty and Said both challenge linear, historicist accounts of cultural development. The work's superimposition of Vidyapati's *viraha* upon modern migration, its insistence that a fourteenth-century poet speaks to a twenty-first-century condition, rejects the historicist assumption that every age possesses its own appropriate aesthetic form. This is not anachronism but a different relation to time.

4. The question of audience. Spivak asks who speaks; Bharucha asks for whom. The work's many audiences—rural performance communities, Maithili readers, and English-speaking scholars—complicate any simple answer. The play exists in different forms for different publics, and those different existences cannot be reduced to a single "original."

5. The limits of theory. Each of these theorists reminds us that theory has limits. Spivak's subaltern ultimately cannot speak; Chakrabarty's non-historicist temporalities are difficult to represent in academic prose; Ramanujan's folk-classical synthesis cannot be wholly captured by scholarly categories; Bharucha's embodied performance escapes documentation; Said's travelling theory always risks becoming another form of appropriation. *Vidyapati's Bidesiya* may succeed precisely by refusing to resolve these tensions, insisting instead on remaining multiple, partial, and incomplete.

Concluding Reflection

In the light of these theoretical traditions, *Vidyapati's Bidesiya* is at once illuminated and unsettled. The work presents itself as a dedication to

Vidyapati, a document of folk tradition, a response to contemporary migration, and a performance script. It resists the kind of theoretical mastery that would confine it to a single meaning, a single origin, or a single audience. Perhaps this is its greatest strength: rather than resolving the tensions between classical and folk, text and performance, past and present, it stages them with an honesty that resonates with theoretical criticism.

Each of the five theoretical perspectives finds an aspect of its own concerns in this work. Spivak sees the mediated voice of the subaltern; Chakrabarty, non-historicist temporalities; Ramanujan, folk-classical continuities; Bharucha, the politics of documenting performance; Said, the work of travelling theory. Yet none claims that the text can be reduced to its framework. The text exceeds theory, as cultural objects often do. That excess makes it worthy of critical attention and keeps the critic's work necessarily provisional, necessarily incomplete, and always open to further readings.

Annexure 3: Vidyapati, the Earliest Poet of Maithili (Before Jyotirishwar) — Gajendra Thakur

Ram Thakur

Let us now turn to the central question.

Until the jasmine opens into bloom,
The bee can take no delight in it. And:
Where is the nectar in an unopened bud?

Bodhi Kayastha

Ugna Mahadev

The Vidyapati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha places particular emphasis on caste and non-caste; purity of blood and caste are important to him. He declares that a person of non-noble birth deserves no compassion at all, and that beauty is the exclusive preserve of the wealthy and the privileged. The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati—the sacred-thread-and-turban Vidyapati celebrated by Kishorikant Mishra's Mithila Cultural Council—holds that caste is the ultimate determining factor in social life. Someone born into a bad lineage, he suggests, can become only a serpent with a wicked mind. The same sacred-thread-and-turban Vidyapati declares any country where the rules of caste do not apply to be a mleccha country. (Upendra Thakur, *Aspects of Society and Economy in Medieval Mithila.*)

All the great men of our forebears belong to our own caste.
"Until the jasmine opens into bloom,
The bee can take no delight in it."

And:

"Where is nectar in a closed bud?"

Phanishwar Nath Renu wrote a reportage piece on *Bidapat Naach*, published in the weekly *Vishwamitra* on 1 August 1945. The report is important because it was written some seven hundred years after Jyotirishwar's account of the same subject; throughout those seven centuries the parallel tradition had kept Vidyapati alive.

Yet Vidyapati was suddenly taken away from the very people who had preserved him. Bideshwar Thakur sang Vidyapati's songs and died crying out that Brahmins had seized Vidyapati by placing a turban upon his head. The same account continues to be repeated by Kanungo Badri Prasad Thakur of Brahmpura, Binod Thakur of Pokharbhira, Saryug Thakur of Rudrapur, Jayram Thakur of Menhath, and the entire village of Bisfi. Shaligram Yadav and Awadhiya Thakur bear witness to Bisfi's tradition. Every kind of specious argument about Vidyapati's birth and origins has

been advanced in this ritualistic appropriation, yet research papers have scarcely mentioned his parallel tradition. This essay is dedicated to the thousands who, like Bideshwar Thakur, kept Vidyapati alive in that parallel tradition between Jyotirishwar's account of Bidapat and Phanishwar Nath Renu's account seven hundred years later.

The Tradition of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa in Mithila and Mithila's Parallel Tradition

Language must have existed before the Ṛgveda, the earliest work of Vedic Sanskrit. Much oral literature—*gāthā*, *nārāśaṃsī*, divine tales, and narratives—must have been composed in it. The Ṛgveda uses the terms *gāthin*, *gātuvit*, and *gāthapati* for the singers of such ballads.

From the Vedic period onward, *gāthā* and *nārāśaṃsī* continued as parallel forms.

Did Vedic Sanskrit emerge from Prakrit, or did Prakrit emerge from Vedic Sanskrit? The popular narratives called *nārāśaṃsī* in the Vedas demonstrate, according to this argument, that the two continued alongside one another for a long time. The parallel tradition affected them both. Consider the Ṛgveda: what does its use of *dūlabha* for *durlabha* (Ṛgveda 4.9.8) demonstrate? What does *paścā* for *paścāt* in the Atharvaveda (10.4.10) demonstrate? And what does *pratisaṃhāya* for *pratisandhāya* in the Gopatha Brāhmaṇa (2.4) demonstrate?

The Aryans came to Mithila from the western part of India, and portions of the Vedas already existed before their arrival. That is why so many words and pronunciations found in Maithili also appear in Vedic Sanskrit but not in classical Sanskrit. Avidyā, the doctrine of karma, the cycle of birth and rebirth, and liberation were, in this account, received by the Aryans from non-Aryan peoples. Hence the Upanishads offer a path to *mokṣa*, not merely a path to heaven. How is liberation attained—through sacrifice? No: through knowledge, reflection, contemplation, and *samādhi*. Under King Janaka's patronage, Yājñavalkya composed the Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad in Tirhut, an area the author describes as non-Aryan.

Commenting on the fifty-seventh verse of the *Sāṃkhyakārikā*, Vācaspati Miśra asks: can one say that because a calf is nourished by unconscious milk, the operation of unconscious Prakṛti can also give living beings the knowledge of liberation? God is complete in himself: for what purpose would he create the world? If creation were for the sake of living beings, they would become bound only after creation; before creation there would be no bondage, so what would call for divine compassion? Creation therefore occurs through Prakṛti, and the individual attains *apavarga* through individual effort. Dissolution, too, occurs through discrimination. Vācaspati's explanation is thus non-theistic, not theistic.

Were God to participate in directing Prakṛti, it would be a conscious act undertaken for a purpose, and God has no need of any such purpose. Gautama of Mithila, credited with the *Nyāyasūtra*, discusses attaining *niḥśreyasa* through knowledge of the sixteen categories, but nowhere among them makes God the agent who grants liberation. The *Vaiśeṣikasūtra* holds that the Vedas were composed by learned people, not by God. Kumārila Bhaṭṭa argues that no trustworthy account of God before creation is possible.

The So-Called Mainstream of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa and Its Parallel Mainstream

Brahmanism and non-Brahmanism have coexisted in Mithila from the beginning. Jyotirishwar writes of the Buddhist side: "terrifying in its sudden appearance." The static tradition designated as that of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa is intent on venerating the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati because of an identity of name. The Ṛgvedic hymn and the *nārāśaṃsī*, the great poet Vidyapati and the turbaned Vidyapati, *mokṣa* and heaven-and-hell: these opposed intellectual currents have existed within Mithila.

The priest Gautama is common to both Videgha Māthava of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa and Nimi of the Purāṇas; the author treats the two priests as one and takes this as the beginning of the Videha kingdom. Māthava's priest Gautama initiated the Mitravinda sacrifice, which Yājñavalkya subsequently revived in the time of Mahājanaka II. While repeating the names of Maitreyī, Yājñavalkya, Sītā, and Janaka, this tradition rapidly instituted Vidyapati's sacred-thread ceremony and the installation of a ceremonial turban. The peaceful speed of that transformation suited the so-called mainstream of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa.

After Madhav Singh's decree concerning the branch genealogical registers (*śākhā pañjī*) in 1760, a new cult of high lineage spread among Brahmins and Kayasthas in Mithila. The *bhalmanus* (*battesagamiya*) subgroup arose among Karna Kayasthas, and the Śrotriya subgroup among Maithil Brahmins. According to the author, physical and mental illnesses increased alarmingly in these two groups, as did polygamy, child marriage, and the number of widows. The peaceful but rapid manner of these changes, too, suited the so-called Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa mainstream.

The Views of Dineshwar Lal Anand and Ramvriksh Benipuri on Vidyapati

Dineshwar Lal Anand was mistaken in believing that the genealogical registers were secret in that period. The *pañjī* had classified Bisfi—of the branch associated with the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati—as *Jaywar*,

a lower rank. Branch registers did not exist before 1760; evidence, the author argues, is that the descendants of the line of Ayachi Mishra occur both in the Śrotriya subgroup and among Brahmins outside it. This would be like finding bulls, but no cows, on the seals of the Indus Valley civilisation: how could bulls have arisen without cows? Anand did not have access to all the facts in the *pañjī*. Perhaps, having been drawn into the propaganda that the Vidyapati of the *Padāvalī* and the Vidyapati of Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha were one person, he thought that connecting the lower ranking of Bisfi in the genealogical records with writing in Avahaṭṭha would explain why Vidyapati Ṭhakkura became a revolutionary. Yet Anand also acknowledges that no collection of the *Padāvalī* compiled in Vidyapati's own hand—or even in his lifetime—is known. How is this possible, when the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati announces the beginning and end of his Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha works so resoundingly, recording which kings and queens inspired him and whose patronage he enjoyed? His books display a full sense of authorship and the power of both Sarasvatī and Lakṣmī. Why, then, not the *Padāvalī*? Anand is silent. The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati describes his patrons but says virtually nothing about himself in his Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭha writings. He even appears to feel pressure while writing Avahaṭṭha, then the literary language of the mainstream. Yet the influence of the Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishwar was so powerful that Maithili songs had to be included in the Sanskrit play *Gorakṣavijaya*, just as Jyotirishwar, the earliest reporter of *Bidapat*, included Maithili songs in his Sanskrit play *Dhūrtasamāgama*.

Govind Jha recognises Vidyapati's tradition in Jyotirishwar's *Vidañot* and discusses it. Why, then, does he fail to carry the investigation back to a Vidyapati predating Jyotirishwar, even while Bideshwar Thakur sings himself to death? How does the place where Vidyapati became thirsty in a play suddenly become the playwright's own village? Everyone writes a play about "my Vidyapati" according to their own convenience.

Ramvriksh Benipuri, too, lacked the genealogical evidence. On the basis of the invention of a subcaste and a legend, he writes laughingly of Keshav Mishra's Vidyapati. This Keshav Mishra of the *Dvaita* appendix was a grandson of Vācaspati II (1400–1490). Another Keshav Mishra, dated to about 1150, wrote the *Tarkabhāṣā*, which Vardhamāna, son of Gaṅgeśa, the author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, discusses in his *Tarkaprakāśa*. Neither Benipuri nor any mainstream researcher in the hundred years after Ananda Coomaraswamy advanced even one step beyond Coomaraswamy's research of 1915. Benipuri repeats the story of Ugna, but says nothing about whether Mahādeva would dance on Mount Kailash to the hardline Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati's *Śaivasarvasvasāra* or to the *nācārī* of the earlier Vidyapati. Like Coomaraswamy, Benipuri knows that a *Bhāgavata* manuscript in the hand of the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha

Vidyapati survives, and the story of how Vidyapati attained *gaṅgālābha*: the Ganges drew him into herself. Like Coomaraswamy, Benipuri has heard of the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati's *Puruṣaparīkṣā*, but has not read it. Had he read it, he would have realised that the story of *gaṅgālābha* there is told of Bodhi Kayastha. A similar story was current about the Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishwar, just as the Ugna story was; it was later attached, through ritual appropriation, to the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati. The account of Bodhi Kayastha in *Puruṣaparīkṣā* is the evidence. Benipuri even calls *Kīrtipatākā* a collection of Maithili songs! Is scholarly research conducted by asking around? Why has the exhausted mainstream failed to advance beyond the foundation laid by Coomaraswamy a century earlier? Because, the author argues, the mainstream shaped by the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa does not permit it. Yet without evidence, Puraditya, a friend of Shivasimha, is declared a Bhumihar Brahmin, just as Ramanath Jha called Govinddas (Jha) a Śrotriya—a claim Sukumar Sen deemed ridiculous—while Ramdev Jha made him a Brahmin and Vermaji, writing in the Laldas memorial volume, made Kalidasa a Kayastha.

The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati opens and closes his books with a complete apparatus of ritual, recalling the kings, queens, and patrons who supported him, yet gives no account of himself. Why did the *Padāvalī* survive in the throats of the people? Why did he not provide it with the same elaborate book-making apparatus? Because, the author argues, those songs had been composed centuries before him, when the ceremonial turban had not yet appeared in Mithila. The names Rupanarayan, Shivasimha, Lakhima, Dev Singh, Har Singh, Padma Singh, Vishwas Devi, Arjun-Amar, Raghav Singh, Rudra Singh, Dhir Singh, Bhairav Singh, Chandra Singh, and others were later inserted into the *Padāvalī*, audibly disrupting the metre of the songs. The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati's *Bhūparikramā* (Dev Singh), *Kīrtilatā* (Kirti Singh and Vir Singh), *Kīrtipatākā*, *Gorakṣavijaya* (Shivasimha), *Likhanāvalī* (Puraditya), *Dānavākyāvalī* (Queen Dhirmati), and other works were manifestly composed under royal patronage. The play *Gorakṣavijaya* was written for the worship of Bhairava; like *Dhūrtasamāgama*, it contained Maithili songs, which the author attributes to the powerful influence of the pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati. Had their names not been alike, Jyotirishwar himself would have been turned into that earlier Vidyapati.

Conclusion

Gaṅgeśa, author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, wrote one book equal, it is said, to twelve thousand books. Professor Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in *A History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila*: "The family which was regarded as low in social position has now disappeared from Mithila … Gaṅgeśa's

family is completely neglected; we cannot even be expected to know the name of his father." Bhattacharya says that Professor R. Jha (Ramanath Jha) supplied him with this information.

Let us turn now to the facts recorded in the genealogical registers. They state explicitly, the author says, that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death and married a woman of the leatherworking community. Why did Ramanath Jha conceal this from Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya? A subgroup spread the story of Gaṅgeśa's transformation from fool to scholar, and a conspiracy was undertaken to efface him.

Gaṅgeśa's son Vardhamāna calls him *sukavi-kairava-kānana-induḥ*, "the moon among the water-lilies of fine poets." Yet the preceding examples, the author argues, help explain the conspiracy through which the poetry of so celebrated a scholar has become unavailable. Vāsudeva was a fellow student of Pakṣadhara Miśra in Bengal; he came to Mithila for his studies, passed the *śalākā* examination, and received the title *Sārvabhauma*. Vāsudeva committed to memory the verses of Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* and Udayana's *Nyāyakusumāñjali*. Pakṣadhara and other teachers in Mithila did not permit students to copy the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*. Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Vāsudeva's pupil, defeated his teacher Pakṣadhara Miśra in debate and thereby won the right to reproduce the text. Vāsudeva and Raghunātha established a school of Navya-Nyāya at Navadvīpa. Pakṣadhara was a contemporary of the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati; with Raghunātha, students from Bengal ceased coming to Mithila.

Grierson declared the Bisfi copperplate granted by Shivasimha to the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati a forgery, because he knew the *Padāvalī* and recognised that its Vidyapati could not have received such a grant. But the copperplate had, the author argues, been given to the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati; Grierson did not consider that there were two different figures. Mahāmahopādhyāya Haraprasad Shastri did consider this distinction and pronounced the copperplate genuine.

Śrīdharadāsa's *Saduktikarṇāmṛta* contains the Kaivarta Papīhā's hymn in praise of the Ganges and songs of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa. Dhoyī, court poet to Lakṣmaṇasena, was a *jolhā* (weaver).

Lakhima Thakurain did not write a *Padāvalī*; she wrote Sanskrit verse (Grierson). The inscription of Śrīdharadāsa is at Andhratharhi; he served as a minister to Nānyadeva and Gaṅgadeva. His descendant Amiyakar was a contemporary of the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭha Vidyapati. Upendra Thakur considers Gaṅgadeva a Kalachuri. Vijay Kumar Thakur takes a Vidyapati song in Śrīdharadāsa's *Saduktikarṇāmṛta* as praise of the Kalachuri Karṇa. Radhakrishna Choudhary disagrees.

In any event, this Vidyapati preceded Jyotirishwar.

In the *Rāmacarita*, Vigrahapāla III defeats Karṇa. Radhakrishna Choudhary found two Pāla inscriptions at Naulagarh, sixteen kilometres north of Begusarai, relating to this episode. This Karṇa, too, belongs to the eleventh century.

The *Padāvalī* of the pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati is well known in Bengal; Jyotirishwar's *Dhūrtasamāgama* is known in South India. After this, the flow of students from Bengal into Mithila ceased, as did the outward movement of Mithila's drama and *Padāvalī*.

Annexure A to Annexure 3

Phanishwar Nath Renu: A Vidyapati of Folk Song

Introduction

While "researching" the great poet Vidyapati, I felt compelled to give one chapter the title "Vidyapati: Poet of Cultivators, Farm Labourers, and Cart Drivers." For even today, in the Purnia–Saharsa region, there are troupes that sing the *Padāvalī* of Vidyapati, act out its feelings, and dance. The leaders of these troupes are generally buffalo-herders, cowherds, or cart drivers. I asked the Maithil pandits about this.

How had it come about? They replied: "Why get caught up in all that? It is because of such fools that Vidyapati is in such a sorry state today. Whenever it takes their fancy, these ordinary people string together four verses in Vidyapati's name ... You are being led astray." Disregarding the prohibitions of Mithila's pandits, I happily prepared for a journey to Saharsa (or *Saharsha*?). Kanchira is a village administered by the district authorities of two different districts. Half the village lies in Saharsa, the other half in Purnia.

The Vidyapati troupe of Kanchira is known in both districts. On the day I reached the village, an unexpected event had just occurred. A political leader who had represented the area for ten years had been defeated at the election. Dancing and singing that night might therefore be interpreted in an entirely different way. Fearing this, Janakdas, leader of the "Vidyapati troupe," would not allow a performance.

The following night he consented, but only after much pleading. After considerable argument and many roundabout, repeated assertions, Janakdas claimed that the "Vidyapati dance" had first originated in his own family. He would never explain the matter in detail. Once he was satisfied that I had not come to extract a thousand or two thousand rupees from the government treasury in the name of a "Vidyapati dance troupe," he struck the *mṛdaṅga*. I watched the performance all night. A boy who

grazed cattle put on a sari and became Radha, distraught by separation, singing through tears: "For how many days, O Hari, will you torment a woman left all alone?" The following day I asked Janakdas about the history of the dance's origin. "Who knows," he replied, "since when the original singing of this dance has been passed down through our family?" The reason for Janakdas's displeasure was my tape recorder. "You have cleverly recorded all the songs on your tape in secret. You have accomplished your work for nothing, have you?" Even after I gave him fifty rupees in cash, he would not answer my question: when, and how, had cultivators, field labourers, herders, and cart drivers begun to sing and dance to Vidyapati's *Padāvalī*? I lay all day on the straw in Janakdas's cattle shed; he showed no pity. Even his young widowed daughter pleaded on my behalf, but he remained unmoved: did I expect him to have a matter that would bring ridicule upon his family "printed" in a "gazette"? Old Janakdas untied his oxen and went out to graze them. I remained in his shed. What happened next I cannot say with certainty: did I hear a story, see a dream, or fall under some "illusion"?

Annexure B to Annexure 3

Bidapat Naach (Original Reportage by Phanishwar Nath Renu)

Bidapat Naach

It is generally believed that this dance originated in Darbhanga district. What condition it has fallen into in its own birthplace hardly needs describing; yet it is still cherished in villages of several North Bihar districts, as well as in Bhagalpur, Purnia, and elsewhere. It has been left as a dance of the "little people." Members of so-called respectable society think it beneath their dignity to watch it. Among Musahars, Dhangars, and Dusadhs, however, the dance is a great attraction at weddings, tonsure ceremonies, and other occasions. A troupe generally consists of seven or eight performers and uses only two musical instruments: the *mṛdaṅga* and the *mañjīrā* (hand cymbals).

Come, then: let us enjoy a performance of *Bidapat Naach*. Put aside your respectability for a little while …

> *Dhrung dhā, dhrung dhā tinnā—the mṛdaṅga burst into sound. Kun kun kun kun … the cymbals joined its rhythm.*
> *"Gaṇanāyakaṃ phaladāyakaṃ paṇḍitam patitam …" Do not laugh. That was the invocation, in pure Sanskrit.*
> *Dhrungā dhrungā dhrungā dhrungā—the mṛdaṅga began to beat.*
> *Kiṅkā, kiṅkā, kiṅkā, kiṅkā—the cymbals kept it company.*

The dancer began circling in every direction in which the accompanying performers (*samājī*) stood. Behind him, the *bipaṭā*—the clown—spun like a top, pulling faces in every conceivable way and crying, "Oy! Oy! Oy! Oy!"

Dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī—the mṛdaṅga shifted its beat to a different tune. Kiṅkā, kiṅkā … Enough for now. You have made us dance long enough. We will return to the story of the performance later.

The accompanying singer joined in.

"O, she entered, supremely delicate,
Swan-gaited darling of Vṛṣabhānu …"
"O, body and mind and face, borne upon the breeze,
The moon rose above the lightning …"
"Then she covered her face in modesty …"
"When my beloved comes into the courtyard,
I shall turn away with the faintest smile;
Kānhā will try so hard to win me …"
"O friend …
All my life I have gazed upon that beauty,
Yet my eyes have never had their fill."

"Listen here, leader-ji."

"Yes?"

"Now listen to me as well."

"Oh, father!
What misfortune have I not endured?
For seven years I paid the interest,
Yet still my debt was not discharged.
My burden only kept growing;
I sold my water pot and took up watchman's work.
I am Fataḳnāth Girdhārī."
Dhrungā-dhrungā, dhidhinnā tinnā …
"O friend!
This is the month of Bhādo, clouds fill the sky,
My house stands empty …"

Beautiful! Beautiful! Vidyapati truly is the cuckoo of Mithila …

There you go rambling again. You are no better than the *bipaṭā*. However often you are warned, like him you cannot hear a song without adding some remark. Look, here comes Mr Bipaṭā once more …

"This is the month of Bhādo, and the rain pours down;
My thatched roof is leaking."

"Ha-ha-ha!" The audience is helpless with laughter. Ah, I forgot to tell you something: the *bipaṭā* imagines himself to be Krishna, and also the lover who has gone abroad. But at the same time he never forgets that he is Kalru Musahar of Halhaliya, and that although he is human, his position, he feels, is no better than that of an ox turning an oil press. When the dancers throw their arms about his neck and display love through pride and wounded pride, making him understand that "Mādhav has abandoned me and gone to a foreign land," he forgets for a moment that he is supposed to be Krishna travelling from Gokul to Mathura. The inequities of his own life rise before him in bodily form and begin to dance, and he sings:

"Neither Ādrā nor Aśleṣā brought rain;
Everywhere I see the grey hair of old women ...
Fish and turtles have fled to the depths;
Will a terrible famine now descend, O friend?
A whole day's labour earns one seer of grain;
How can life be sustained on that?
Leaving you behind, beloved, I must go away to another land."

But in the very next moment, when the performer begins to sing:

"Carrying her darling in her lap, she went to market;
The people in the bazaar asked, 'What relation is he to you?'
'My mother-in-law's boy, my sister-in-law's husband's elder brother—
He is my husband, allotted to me by destiny.'"

The *bipaṭā* now begins clamouring like a child for *jalebi*, *batasha*, and toys.

Just then one of the dancing performers sings:

"When night gave way to dawn,
My husband returned.
His skilful hands trembled; the necklace burned against my breast;
With lotus hands upon my heart, he gazed at my moonlike face."

The *bipaṭā* interrupts and asks one of the accompanying performers to explain its meaning. The performer launches into an expansive commentary on the song: how the heroine lay sleeping upon straw in her hut, and how the *bipaṭā* arrived there.

Now come among the spectators. Young women, dark-skinned, strong, and full-bodied, struggle to conceal their gentle smiles. Nudging one another and whispering with delight, they stare intently at the *bipaṭā*. Middle-aged women feign indignation and try to restrain the younger women, but what can restrain suppressed laughter or a heart bursting with amusement?

Meanwhile the dancers raise their voices in a sustained melody:

"Come, my heart, come, my heart ... to my husband's home
We shall go, O Rama;
For, O Rama, in my parents' home
Shall I set a fire ...?"

The young women grow restless, while electricity seems to course through the young men's veins. The dance is nearing its end:

"Come, my heart, come, my heart ...
Dhin dhinak dhinak, dhin dhinak dhinak ...
For, O Rama, shall I set fire to my parents' home ...?
Dim dimik dimik, dim dimik dimik ..."

What is this? Oh, it is Chethru Gusain-ji. Gusain-ji is a devotee of Kabir. Ten or fifteen years ago, at the landlord's bidding, he refused to give false testimony. Angered, the landlord turned him out of his home, and ever since he has lived as a renunciant. A *khanjari*, a begging bag and tongs; matted locks and a long beard ... Look! Gusain-ji begins to play his *khanjari* and dance beside the performers.

"Dim dimik dimik, dim dimik dimik ...
For, O Rama, in my parents' home shall I set fire ..."

The fact is that Chethru Gusain-ji regards this song as entirely *nirguṇa*—a song of the formless divine.

Ah! Tears glisten in his sunken eyes. And the dance is over.

(Phanishwar Nath Renu's reportage appeared in the weekly *Vishwamitra* on 1 August 1945. This Maithili translation from Hindi, by Madhupnath Jha, published in *Videha: Sadeh* II, is dedicated to Phanishwar Nath Renu.)

Annexure 4: Beyond Vidyapati's Bidesiya, Piya Desāntar and Bidāpat Nāch: A Parallel World of Maithili Theatre

Vidyapati's Piya Desāntar

Scene 1

Here no king grants anyone peace.
All the great men of earlier generations belong to my own kin.

Scene 2

O traveller, take your rest here.
O traveller! Rest here.

Scene 3

Here, my friend, learn the story of my beloved.

Scene 4

Scene 5

Scene 6

Scene 7

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76. Jayakant Mishra and the Maithili Dictionary

Abstract

Jayakant Mishra (1922–2009), a pioneer of Maithili studies, died at seven in the evening on 3 February 2009. A major scholar of Maithili literature, Dr Jayakant Mishra retired in 1982 as Professor and Head of the Department of English and Modern European Languages at the University of Allahabad. He subsequently served as Dean of Languages and Social Sciences at Chitrakoot Gramodaya University.

Keywords: Jayakant Mishra; Maithili dictionary; lexicography; semantics; language history; corpus; dictionary tradition

Jayakant Mishra (1922–2009), a pioneer of Maithili studies, died at seven in the evening on 3 February 2009. A major scholar of Maithili literature, Dr Jayakant Mishra retired in 1982 as Professor and Head of the Department of English and Modern European Languages at the University of Allahabad. He subsequently served as Dean of Languages and Social Sciences at Chitrakoot Gramodaya University. The late Mishra was President of the All India Maithili Sahitya Samiti, Allahabad; honorary secretary and editor of the Ganganath Research Institute, Allahabad; convenor of the management department of the Hindi Sahitya Sammelan, Prayag; and the Maithili representative and language editor of the Sahitya Akademi, New Delhi. Among his books are History of Maithili Literature, Folk Literature of Mithila, critical editions of Kirtaniya dramas, Lectures on Thomas Hardy, Lectures on Four Poets and The Complex Style in English Poetry. Only two volumes of his great Maithili dictionary could be published. Its Maithili headwords were given not only in Devanagari but also in Mithilakshar and English phonetic transcription. These two volumes will remain a source of inspiration to compilers of Maithili dictionaries. The sixteen-volume Maithili–English dictionary based on the Videha database, by Gajendra Thakur, Nagendra Kumar Jha and the genealogist Vidyanand Jha, presents words and meanings in Mithilakshar, International Phonetic Roman script and Devanagari. It has been dedicated to Jayakant Mishra, Dinbandhu Jha and Govind Jha, Bhavanath Mishra and Matinath Mishra ‘Matang’, and Yugalkishore Mishra.

The making of Maithili dictionaries began comparatively late. The first serious effort was the collection of 1,125 verbal roots and forms in Dinbandhu Jha’s Mithila Bhasha Vidyotan (1946), followed by his Mithilabhashakosh: Shabdakosh (1952). Earlier, the first volume of Bhav Nath Mishra’s Mithila Shabda Prakash had appeared in 1914, but it was so brief that it might better be called a glossary than a dictionary. Alice Irvine Davis’s Basic Colloquial Maithili: A Maithili–Nepali–English Vocabulary (1984) is likewise very brief. The Maithili Akademi’s Maithili

Shabdakosh (1993; originally compiled by Yugalkishore Mishra) was the first to appear on an ambitious scale. Yet, among its long list of convenors, editors, executive editors, editorial subcommittees and so on, Yugalkishore Mishra's name seems to have been squeezed into the middle merely as the 'original compiler'.

Meanwhile, the first volume of Jayakant Mishra's comprehensive Maithili dictionary appeared in 1973 and the second in 1995. Together, they could cover entries beginning with the vowels from a to au and only the first page of words beginning with ka. With Jayakant Babu's death, the appearance of further volumes is now no longer possible.

Matinath Mishra 'Matang', son of Bhav Nath Mishra, published Maithili Shabda Kalpadruma in 1998. Following the Maithili Akademi, Patna, dictionary compiled by Yugalkishore Mishra, this was the second large-scale compilation to appear. It also reproduced, at the beginning, the first volume of Bhav Nath Mishra's Mithila Shabda Prakash.

Dinbandhu Jha's son Govind Jha published the Maithili–English dictionary Kalyani Kosh in 1999. Like Jayakant Babu's dictionary, it was bilingual, providing English meanings alongside Maithili words. In 2007 Umesh Chandra Jha's concise quadrilingual dictionary (Maithili, Sanskrit, Hindi and English) also appeared.

In addition, a comprehensive Maithili dictionary has also been proposed by Sajha Prakashan, Nepal.

English Dictionaries Based on Databases

Apart from historically significant English dictionaries, three modern dictionaries deserve mention for their scientific approach grounded in databases or computerised corpora of written and spoken language—words drawn from periodicals, books, conversations, radio and television programmes, and manuscripts: 1. Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary (from its first edition of 1948 to its seventh edition of 1995);

2. Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English (from its first edition of 1978 to its fifth edition of 2009); and

3. Collins COBUILD Advanced Learner's English Dictionary (from its first edition of 1995 to its sixth edition of 2008).

Microsoft Encarta Dictionary, available on CD and online, also provides audio recordings of pronunciation. The CD editions of Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary and other dictionaries likewise provide recorded pronunciations.

The excellence of a dictionary should be judged by the vocabulary it collects. First, readers must be able to find the word they are seeking. That

is impossible unless the dictionary is up to date, grounded in fieldwork across all regions of Mithila and attentive to new usages among Maithili speakers living elsewhere. It must include new subjects such as the internet, science, the arts, commerce, computing and contemporary developments. Scholarly judgement must work alongside technology in selecting material; the corpus should embrace games and sport, everyday conversation, written literature and oral traditions. Definition is equally important: the linguistic analysis of a selected word must be fine-grained enough to leave out none of its contextual meanings. In this connection, it is worth noting that if Dinbandhu Jha's 1,125 verbal roots and forms were enlarged and revised slightly, bringing the set to roughly 2,000 basic words, Maithili speakers whose command of the language is not strong could use them to understand the meanings and contexts of all the entries in a Maithili dictionary of 50,000 to 100,000 words.

The meanings of dictionary entries should be ordered from the most frequent to the least frequent. Spoken pronunciation and actual usage must also be attended to. Readers should be told which words are common and which occur only occasionally. Proverbs, too, should be illustrated wherever appropriate with examples of use.

Compounds, proverbial compounds, derivatives, synonyms and antonyms must be collected with the relevant headword. The dictionary should also show how additional words combine with a word or idiom, and how the resulting expressions can carry the same or a related meaning.

Grammatical discussion should be provided where appropriate, showing similarities as well as differences. Changes in a word's meaning according to its use in a sentence must be explained.

Illustrations are also needed to clarify dictionary entries. A modern scientific dictionary should represent variations in pronunciation.

The contextual use of idioms and proverbs should also be recorded wherever such usage exists. For instance, Brahmins may say, 'Ten Brahmins, ten stomachs; ten rāṛ, one stomach,' whereas those described as occupying the lower rungs of the caste hierarchy may say, 'Ten Brahmins, one stomach; ten rāṛ, ten stomachs.'

Dinbandhu Jha's Dhātupāṭha in Mithilabhasha Vidyotan provides particularly fine accounts of the derivation of meanings. For example, entry (10), ḍik, means 'the accumulation of an excess': 'This place is deep, and therefore water has ḍikaled here'—that is, an excess of water has collected. The forty-three tables in the two volumes of Mithila Bhasha Vidyotan describe the etymology of Maithili words in considerable detail. The introduction to Dinbandhu Jha's Mithila Bhasha Kosh also examines the syntactic relationships, pronunciation, grammatical gender and

grammar of many words. The dictionary proper gives, for most though not all entries, the word, its constituent parts, grammatical characteristics and meaning. At places it records variant forms and changes of meaning when words are combined with verbs and other elements. In the Maithili Akademi, Patna, dictionary compiled by Yugalkishore Mishra, the headword is followed by its grammatical characteristics and meaning. Alice Irvine Davis's Basic Colloquial Maithili: A Maithili–Nepali–English Vocabulary (1984) uses only Roman and phonetic Roman letters, giving a Maithili headword, its grammatical properties and its meanings in Nepali and English. After some structural notes, it provides Nepali and English indexes through which Nepali-to-Maithili and English-to-Maithili meanings may be found. Bhavanath Mishra's Mithila Shabda Prakash gives a word in the language of Mithila, then its meanings in Hindi and Sanskrit, then its grammatical gender, and finally a Sanskrit citation as evidence. Matinath Mishra 'Matang' presents in Maithili Shabda Kalpadruma the Maithili word, its grammatical features and meaning, and finally identifies whether it is Maithili, regional/indigenous (deśaja), tatsama or tadbhava. Govind Jha's Kalyani Kosh: A Maithili–English Dictionary includes some analyses of structure and pronunciation in its preface and tables in the appendices of verbal suffixes, nominal suffixes and units; solar months and lunar mansions; lunar months; different eras; weights, measures, linear and square measures; currency; and miscellaneous calculations. The dictionary proper gives the Maithili word in Devanagari, then its transcription in a Roman phonetic alphabet, its grammatical characteristics, and its meaning in Maithili and English. Alternative meanings and contextual uses are sometimes supplied. Umesh Chandra Jha's quadrilingual dictionary gives the Maithili headword with Sanskrit, Hindi and English equivalents. C-DAC's Tāntrāṃśa software dictionaries, Maithili–English and English–Maithili, give English meanings when Maithili is entered and Maithili meanings when English is entered. The Maithili–English and English–Maithili dictionaries by Gajendra Thakur, Nagendra Kumar Jha and the genealogist Vidyanand Jha have been developed from the Videha database and corpus. They are available in print and online (at http://w ww.videha.co.in/) and are continually being expanded. Alongside modern fields, these dictionaries include the vocabulary of the internet, computers and science. At present the Maithili–English dictionary presents the Maithili headword in the International Phonetic Alphabet, then transliterations of that word in Devanagari and Mithilakshar, followed by its meaning in the International Phonetic Alphabet, Devanagari and Mithilakshar, and finally its meaning in English and its grammatical features. The English–Maithili dictionary drawn from the Videha corpus gives the English word and its grammatical features, then its meaning in the International Phonetic Alphabet, Devanagari and Mithilakshar, and finally its meaning in English. Once

the whole database has been printed, the plan for a second edition is to arrange meanings in order from more frequent to less frequent; include compounds, proverb-based compounds, derivatives, synonyms and antonyms; discuss the grammatical similarities and differences among words used with idioms; add illustrations; show the contextual use of idioms and proverbs; and supply sentence examples from the Videha corpus. It is further proposed to provide a Tāntrāṃśa software dictionary on CD with recorded pronunciations. Pronunciation audio files, in any case, have already been placed online in the archive at http://www.videha.co.in/ for listening and download.

Jayakant Mishra and the Maithili Dictionary: An Assessment

A dictionary is not so much written as compiled. Yet, when a subject is new, words sometimes have to be coined with reference to oral and literary traditions, while borrowings from other languages must also be accepted where appropriate. Though a dictionary's principal purpose is collection, in practice it inevitably advances standardisation and influences popular usage. For that reason, the responsibility of the dictionary editor becomes all the greater.

Seen in this light, Jayakant Mishra's dictionary is inferior to no modern dictionary. Indeed, it goes a step further: to establish the meaning of a word, it gives contextual examples drawn from corpora covering early Maithili (from the eighth century to 1324 CE, including the Caryāpada and Jyotirishwar), the earlier medieval period (1324–1500 CE, including Vidyapati), the medieval period (1500–1860 CE, including Lochan and Govind Das), and modern Maithili (1860–1960 CE, including Chanda Jha and Harimohan Jha).

Jayakant Mishra's Maithili dictionary and the work of further study entitled Jayakant Mishra and the Maithili Dictionary can thus become complementary to one another if his work is carried forward and completed.

77. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

Abstract

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya: Life, Logic, the Tattvacintāmaṇi, and His Legacy in the Navya-Nyāya Tradition. Life, Logic, the Tattvacintāmaṇi, and His Legacy in the Navya-Nyāya Tradition. The land of Mithila has been one of Asia's most consistently productive centres of Sanskrit intellectual culture.

Keywords: Gaṅgeśa · Upādhyāya · Theory of Criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Summary

This integrated study brings into a single sequence Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's biography, evidence from pañjī genealogical registers, the four pramāṇa divisions of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, the validity and invalidity of cognition, perception–inference–comparison–testimony, vyāpti, kārakavāda, the avacchedaka-based language of Navya-Nyāya, the commentary tradition, comparative perspectives in world philosophy, and Mithila's parallel intellectual history. Repeated discussions have been consolidated as far as possible while preserving the original arguments, examples, archival particulars, and technical analyses.

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya: Life, Logic, the Tattvacintāmaṇi, and His Legacy in the Navya-Nyāya Tradition

Special Article

Life, Logic, the Tattvacintāmaṇi, and His Legacy in the Navya-Nyāya Tradition

Outline · 1. Life, Context, and the Initial Philosophical Framework · 2. Detailed Epistemological Examination · 3. Technical Navya-Nyāya, Kārakavāda, and Modern Readings · 4. Archival Evidence, the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa, and Cultural Reinterpretation · Appendices · Bibliography

Part I · Life, Context, and Philosophical Outline

Biography: A Three-Tiered Appraisal of Sources

A distinctive contribution of these chapters is their multilayered presentation of Gaṅgeśa's life. The traditional miracle stories—the supposedly slow-witted boy, the boon from Kālī, the humiliation in his maternal uncle's household—are treated as narratives; historical dating (around 1320 CE, the reign of Harisiṃhadeva, and residence at Kariyan) is considered through documentary sources; and social particulars drawn from the pañjī registers—birth five years after his father's death, a marriage across caste boundaries to a woman of the leatherworking community, and the evidence of the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī—constitute a third,

parallel evidentiary stream. This three-tiered appraisal of sources distinguishes the book from conventional biography and brings it closer to modern historiographical method.

Introduction: A Philosopher of Mithila

The land of Mithila has been one of Asia's most continuously productive centres of Sanskrit intellectual culture. It was here, in King Janaka's court, that the philosophical dialogues of the Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad took place. Yājñavalkya, Gautama, and Kātyāyana—central names in the Nyāya-sūtra tradition and Vedic grammar—are all assigned a Maithil origin or association. It was here that the poet Vidyāpati sang in Maithili, raising the literature of the people to greatness; and here, according to this account, the astronomer-mathematician Āryabhaṭa drew his earliest intellectual breath. In this productive, disputatious, profoundly scholastic setting, Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya composed the work that changed the face of Indian philosophy.

Early in the fourteenth century, Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya composed the Tattvacintāmaṇi—The Jewel of Reflection on Truth—and permanently transformed India's intellectual landscape. The Tattvacintāmaṇi (literally, 'the thought-jewel of truth', also called Pramāṇacintāmaṇi or simply Cintāmaṇi) is his sole surviving major work. It is a treatise on pramāṇa, the valid means of knowledge, divided into four books: (1) Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa (perception), (2) Anumāna-khaṇḍa (inference), (3) Upamāna-khaṇḍa (comparison or analogy), and (4) Śabda-khaṇḍa (verbal testimony). The Tattvacintāmaṇi is Gaṅgeśa's only surviving work and one of the most extensively commented-upon texts in the Sanskrit tradition. Abandoning the older Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika ambition to cover the full range of categories and restricting the inquiry to the means of knowledge, Gaṅgeśa gave the tradition a more sharply defined aim and, correspondingly, a new name. Nyāya literature before him is called Prācīna-Nyāya, or old logic; that following his work is Navya-Nyāya, or new logic. Simplified though this periodisation is, it captures a real qualitative transformation: in terminology, method, standards of analytical exactness, and the displacement of older commentaries by the Tattvacintāmaṇi as the school's central text.

Although Gaṅgeśa consolidated the school, the true founder of the method he brought to perfection was the eleventh-century polymath Udayanācārya, whose Pariśuddhi and Kusumāñjali mark the threshold at which the classical age of Nyāya came to an end. Modern scholarly consensus, including the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, identifies Gaṅgeśa as a mahopādhyāya ('great teacher') in the kingdom of Mithila.

In mainstream Indian philosophical historiography, Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya is revered as the undisputed architect of Navya-Nyāya. In his Hindi monograph, Bhāratīya Sāhitya ke Nirmātā: Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, Udayanath Jha 'Ashok' places Gaṅgeśa's dates at approximately 1300–1350 CE. Jha portrays a scholar who earned the prestigious title Mahāmahopādhyāya, a distinction reserved in Mithila for philosophers of exceptional mastery in Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, and Dharmaśāstra.

Likewise, Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya's History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila traces the region's intellectual genealogy, mapping the development from Gautama's earlier prameya-centred (ontological) Nyāya to Gaṅgeśa's pramāṇa-centred (epistemological) rigour.

Comparison of these polished, orthodox accounts with the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī —the genealogical register of social transgressions or 'faults' in Mithila— reveals a significant discrepancy, documented at length in the research undertaken for Videha's Parallel History.

The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī, according to this account, discloses two startling biographical particulars about Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya:

1. Posthumous birth: Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death.

2. Marriage recorded in the pañjī: Gaṅgeśa married Vallabhā, a woman identified as a carmakāriṇī, belonging to the leatherworking community.

The Historiographical 'Honour Killing' of Truth

The discrepancy between mainstream works and the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī, the author argues, is not accidental: it represents active historiographical suppression. Professor Ramanath Jha, a central figure in the modern Maithili pañjī system, is mentioned in the Parallel History records in connection with the suppression of these particular Dūṣaṇa Pañjī entries.

Because Gaṅgeśa had brought Mithila to the position of an undisputed capital of Indian logic, acknowledgement of his posthumous birth and marriage outside his caste threatened the Brahmanical narratives of purity of that age. Consequently, orthodox historians engaged in what the Parallel History calls 'the honour killing of his legacy'. Udayanath Jha's recent monograph, in this interpretation, perpetuates that silence by concentrating wholly on Gaṅgeśa's Sanskrit titles and philosophical stature while disregarding the sociohistorical reality of his marginalised personal background. Recognition of this suppression matters to modern scholarship because it presents Gaṅgeśa not merely as an elite logician but as a brilliant mind who overcame immense social exclusion.

The Transition to Navya-Nyāya: A Paradigm Shift from Prameya to Pramāṇa

As Karl H. Potter notes in the Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies (Volume 6), classical Nyāya dealt with sixteen categories, encompassing ontology, epistemology, and the dialectics of disputation. Gaṅgeśa initiated an unprecedented paradigm shift by setting aside that vast metaphysical framework and concentrating exclusively on pramāṇa—the valid means by which knowledge is acquired.

By devoting the Tattvacintāmaṇi entirely to epistemology, Gaṅgeśa developed a language of extraordinary technical precision. He created new logical operators, such as avacchedaka (delimitor), to avoid ambiguity—a method whose analytical rigour Stephen Phillips and Ben-Ami Scharfstein compare with that of twentieth-century Western analytic philosophers such as Frege and Russell.

The Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa

The first and foundational book of the Tattvacintāmaṇi is the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa, on perception. Drawing on the detailed translations and explanations of V. P. Bhatta and S. C. Vidyabhusana, this book defines the mechanisms of perceptual cognition.

Maṅgalavāda and Prāmāṇyavāda (the Validity of Knowledge)

Gaṅgeśa begins with maṅgalavāda, the theory of auspicious invocation, justifying the necessity of invoking the deity Śiva for the successful completion of an undertaking. He then turns to the intensely contested prāmāṇyavāda, the theory of validity.

- The Mīmāṃsaka position: Prabhākara and Kumārila argued for svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic validity): cognition, from the very moment it arises, establishes its own validity.
- Gaṅgeśa's Naiyāyika position: Gaṅgeśa vigorously defends parataḥ-prāmāṇya (extrinsic validity). He argues that a cognition's validity is not intrinsically known through that very cognition; it is inferred subsequently from successful practical activity (saṃvādi-pravṛtti). For example, merely seeing water is confirmed as valid knowledge only when a person approaches it and succeeds in quenching their thirst.

Sannikarṣa (Sense–Object Contact)

Perception (pratyakṣa) is defined as cognition produced by contact between a sense faculty and its object (indriyārtha-sannikarṣa). Gaṅgeśa describes six forms of ordinary contact:

1. Saṃyoga (conjunction): for example, seeing a pot with one's eyes.

2. Saṃyukta-samavāya (inherence in a conjoined object): seeing the colour of the pot.

3. Saṃyukta-samaveta-samavāya (inherence in what inheres in a conjoined object): perceiving the universal 'colourness' through the eye.

4. Samavāya (inherence): hearing a sound with the ear.

5. Samaveta-samavāya (inherence in an inherent property): apprehending the universal 'soundness' through the ear.

6. Viśeṣaṇa-viśeṣya-bhāva (the qualifier–qualified relation): perceiving an absence, such as the absence of a pot on the floor.

Savikalpaka and Nirvikalpaka

• Nirvikalpaka (indeterminate perception): a raw, preconceptual apprehension of an object, without its qualifications. It is inexpressible and nonlinguistic.

• Savikalpaka (determinate perception): apprehension of an object in relation to its properties, as in 'This is a blue pot'. Only determinate perception can be expressed in language and judged true or false.

Alaukika Sannikarṣa (Extraordinary Perception)

Gaṅgeśa outlines three kinds of extraordinary perception, distinguishing Nyāya from Western empiricism:

1. Sāmānyalakṣaṇa: through the perception of one member, apprehending the members of an entire universal class—for example, recognising 'smoke' in general upon perceiving a particular instance of smoke.

2. Jñānalakṣaṇa: a cross-sensory perception grounded in memory, such as seeing a piece of sandalwood and 'perceiving' its fragrance without smelling it.

3. Yogaja: yogic or mystical perception of hidden objects or things belonging to the past or future.

The Anumāna-khaṇḍa

The Anumāna-khaṇḍa, extensively translated by V. P. Bhatta and closely analysed by Stephen Phillips, forms the core of Navya-Nyāya's logical architecture.

The Concept of Vyāpti (Invariable Concomitance)

Inference depends upon vyāpti, the invariable relation between the hetu (reason or sign, such as smoke) and the sādhya (the property to be established, such as fire). Gaṅgeśa examines the vyāptipañcaka, five

provisional definitions of pervasion advanced by earlier logicians, and rejects all five because they fail in cases involving properties located in different substrates. He then establishes his own siddhānta-lakṣaṇa (final definition): vyāpti means the absence of the reason wherever the probandum is absent.

Īśvarānumāna (Inference to the Existence of God)

Gaṅgeśa devotes a section to establishing God's existence by inference. He argues that the earth, sprouts, and similar things must have an intelligent maker because they are effects, just as a pot is the product of a potter. This argument directly challenges atheistic Mīmāṃsā and Buddhist schools.

Hetvābhāsa (Fallacies of Reasoning)

Gaṅgeśa offers a fine-grained classification of logical fallacies (hetvābhāsa, 'what appears to be a reason but is not'). These include savyabhicāra (inconclusive or irregular reason), viruddha (contradictory reason), satpratipakṣa (an equally strong counterreason), asiddha (unestablished reason), and bādhita (reason contradicted by stronger evidence).

The Upamāna-khaṇḍa

Where Buddhist and Vaiśeṣika thinkers had subsumed comparison under inference, Gaṅgeśa defends it as an independent pramāṇa. Upamāna is the process by which a person learns the meaning of a word through perceived resemblance. For example, a townsman is told that a gavaya (wild ox) looks like a cow. When he enters a forest and sees an animal resembling a cow, recollection of the description and the visible similarity together produce valid knowledge: 'This is the animal to which the word gavaya refers.'

The Śabda-khaṇḍa

In the final book, Gaṅgeśa analyses words, meanings, and sentences. Śabda is defined as āptopadeśa, instruction from a trustworthy and authoritative speaker. He identifies four necessary conditions for a sentence to convey meaningful knowledge:

1. Ākāṅkṣā (expectancy): the syntactic need of words to complete one another, as when the command 'Bring' prompts the question 'What?'

2. Yogyatā (semantic fitness): the logical compatibility of the words, lacking, for example, in 'He waters the plant with fire.'

3. Sannidhi (proximity): the utterance of words in close temporal succession.

4. Tātparya (speaker's intention): the context or intended meaning of the speaker, especially important for ambiguous words such as saindhava, which can mean either salt or a horse.

As S. C. Vidyabhusana explains, Gaṅgeśa expressly rejects gestures, popular report, and tradition (aitihya) as independent pramāṇas, treating them instead under testimony or inference.

According to the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (SEP) and Ben-Ami Scharfstein's A Comparative History of World Philosophy, the Navya-Nyāya school represents one of the high points of global intellectual achievement.

Where Western philosophy frequently separates epistemology, ontology, and linguistics, Gaṅgeśa brought them together in a single language of exceptional technical exactness. Stephen Phillips emphasises that Gaṅgeśa's definition of true cognition (pramā)—cognition corresponding to reality without the intrusion of subjective doubt—places Navya-Nyāya firmly within a robust epistemological realism. Scharfstein observes that its scholastic intensity is closely comparable to Western medieval scholasticism, as exemplified by Thomas Aquinas or William of Ockham, but that its linguistic articulation is mathematically precise.

A study of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya requires a balance between his extraordinary philosophical intelligence and the harsh sociopolitical realities of his age. The monograph by Udayanath Jha 'Ashok' and the historiography of Ramanath Jha preserve his philosophical legacy; a full presentation of the social and biographical particulars preserved in the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī is another matter. The Tattvacintāmaṇi remains a masterpiece of unparalleled logical precision. At the same time, the pañjī evidence, as presented here, states that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death and married a woman of the leatherworking community. These particulars need to be read as an archival stream of evidence distinct from traditional narratives.

What was the author's actual name? The answer is that Gaṅgeśvara was his formal or ceremonial name, while Gaṅgeśa was his everyday or familiar name. The text considers this firmly established by two kinds of evidence. First, in the opening benedictory verse (maṅgalācaraṇa) of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, Gaṅgeśa himself writes in the first person, 'gaṅgeśa-stute mitena vacase śrī-tattva-cintāmaṇim', using the name Gaṅgeśa. Second, his son and principal disciple Vardhamāna, in the Kiraṇāvalī-prakāśa, explicitly salutes his father and teacher as Gaṅgeśvara: 'nyāyāmbhoja-pataṅgāya mīmāṃsā-pāradṛśvane / gaṅgeśvarāya gurave pitre śvabhavate namaḥ'. The name Gaṅgeśvara also appears in the Kusumāñjali-prakāśa. Thus the two names are not those of separate individuals but the formal and informal designations of one person.

The pañjī genealogical records mention both names in relation to the same biographical places and relationships, and the village 'Chādana' is

cited in the Pañjī-prabandha with the expression 'chādanaṃ tattva-cintāmaṇi-kāraka mahāmahopādhyāya paramaguruḥ gaṅgeśvaraḥ'. Moreover, Vardhamāna's explicit testimony makes it impossible, on this account, to maintain that the two names refer to different people. The author who wrote 'gaṅgeśa-stute' in his own work was saluted by his son as 'gaṅgeśvara gurave pitre'. In that same verse Vardhamāna also speaks of his father's mastery of Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā, a feature that occurs in Gaṅgeśa's own benedictory verse as well.

Gaṅgeśa's birthplace has been the subject of considerable scholarly dispute. Different scholars have proposed different villages: (1) Maṅgraunī (or Maṅgalvanī), in Madhubani district; (2) Kiryān (also Kiriyāṃ), a village twelve miles south-east of Darbhanga; (3) Chakautī; and (4) Chājaṃ (historically Chādana), now near Turki railway station in Muzaffarpur district. The pañjī records, treated in this account as the most authoritative evidence on such questions, consistently describe Gaṅgeśa as 'Chādana-saṃbhūta', a native of Chādana/Chājaṃ. Chājaṃ, about three kilometres west of Turki Chowk and surrounded by villages such as Rupaulī, Bahilvārā, and Supnā—the last associated with Gaṅgeśa's son Sūpana—is presented as the most likely site. The Tibetan traveller Dharmasvāmin, who visited Mithila during the reign of the Karṇāṭa ruler Rāmasiṃhadeva (1234 CE), mentioned a place called 'To-ki', where many Jains and Buddhists lived. That 'To-ki' is identified here with present-day Turki, near Gaṅgeśa's village Chājaṃ. A minority view, advanced by Rajendranath Ghosh on the basis of Bengali sources, holds that Gaṅgeśa was Bengali. Ghosh himself ultimately describes him as an inhabitant of Mithila and a Maithil Brahmin. According to M. M. Phanibhushan Tarkavagish, the pañjī records name his birthplace 'Maṅgaurī', but the village-specific genealogical entries point more consistently to Chādana.

Gaṅgeśa belonged to the Kāśyapa gotra. His mūla—the ancestral village affiliation recognised in the pañjī system—was 'Sirisbe-Chādana': he belonged to the Sirisbā ancestral line, specifically its Chādana branch. The pañjī records identify him as a Kāśyapa-gotra member of the 'Sirisbe-Chādana mūla'. His father's name was Girīśvara Upādhyāya, who died five years before Gaṅgeśa was born.

Some pañjī records indicate that his formal name was Gaṅgeśvara and his familiar name Gaṅgeśa. He had two wives. By the first he had a daughter and his eldest son, Vardhamāna; by the second, the sons Sūpana and Hara. The pañjī evidence also records that Vardhamāna's daughter married into the Khāṇḍvālā mūla of the Śāṇḍilya gotra (the lineage of Śivanātha, son of Viśvanātha); that Vardhamāna's son and the Chandraka–Balabhadra–Śobhā line had marriages with families originating in Chādana; that Sūpana's daughter married into the Jijivālā mūla of the Śāṇḍilya gotra; and

that Sūpana himself married into the Bhāṇḍārisamaya mūla. According to P. Rajendranath Ghosh, Gaṅgeśa lost his father early and was raised at his maternal uncle's home in the village of Kiryān, where the uncle ran a school. As a boy, Gaṅgeśa at first displayed little scholarly aptitude and was regarded, to a degree, as a slow learner. A legend, circulated in several versions, recounts that Gaṅgeśa was once teased by his uncle's wife, who called him 'gauḥ'—'cow' or 'fool'. The incident supposedly inspired an extraordinary Sanskrit play on words involving gotva ('cowness', or clan identity), which Gaṅgeśa composed spontaneously. His uncle recognised the unexpected intelligence it disclosed, embraced the boy, and promised to teach him everything. Whether or not this story is literally true, it symbolically expresses a genuine philosophical point: the verse about gotva is itself a miniature exercise in the problem of universals (sāmānya), which lies at the heart of Navya-Nyāya reasoning. It is therefore particularly fitting that the earliest folk legend about Gaṅgeśa should centre on a punning philosophical argument concerning gotva.

N. S. Ramanuja Tatacharya's work states that Gaṅgeśa had one son by his first wife and two sons, Sūpana and Hara, by his second; the eldest was Vardhamāna. None of the three brothers—Vardhamāna, Sūpana, and Hara—had male descendants.

But the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī has more to say.

The work set in motion a philosophical revolution whose influence was felt in Mithila, Bengal, Navadvīpa, Madras, Maharashtra, Kashmir, and eventually the whole of India, making the Sanskrit scholarship of the past five hundred years unimaginable without it. The connection with Mithila is not merely biographical. Gaṅgeśa's homeland remained an intellectual centre of Navya-Nyāya scholarship, and that intellectual inheritance survives today in the journal Videha (Videha web archive, ISSN 2229-547X), which since its inception (around 2000) has served as a digital repository for the Maithili language, literature, and culture—the civilisational soil on which Gaṅgeśa stood. The Videha archive maintains digital editions of writings connected with Mithila's history, its philosophers, and its literary traditions, including pre-Vidyāpati poetry and pañjī records. Gaṅgeśa thus belongs not only to the history of philosophy but also to the living cultural memory that Maithil scholars continue to retrieve and circulate.

The university of Navadvīpa, founded in 1503 CE, became the principal vehicle for the popularity of the Tattvacintāmaṇi in Bengal, largely through the great commentator Raghunātha Śiromaṇi. From Bengal the work spread to Madras, Maharashtra, and Kashmir; within two centuries it was known across the subcontinent. As Satish Chandra Vidyabhusana notes in his introduction, 'In modern India no Sanskrit scholarship is

reckoned of any value unless it is accompanied by a knowledge of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, or at least of some part of it.'

Gaṅgeśa, also called Gaṅgeśvara and bearing the surname Upādhyāya, was a philosopher of early fourteenth-century Mithila. Modern scholarship places his period of activity around 1320 CE, corresponding to the reign of Harisiṃhadeva. Kariyan/Kariyon is associated with traditions concerning his residence; the pañjī records also mention the Chādana/Chādanā ancestral line. Residence and ancestral village should therefore not be treated as synonyms for birthplace. No definite year of birth can be established from the records. The decisive biographical information claimed from the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī is that he was born five years after his father's death.

In the premodern period, Mithila's intellectual standing rested upon its system of scholastic patronage, which supported paṇḍits—learned specialists—in many disciplines. The region's Brahmin families maintained expertise across generations in Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, Vedānta, grammar, astrology, and law. Gaṅgeśa worked within this tradition and was recognised by his contemporaries as jagadguru ('distinguished professor', in Vidyabhusana's rendering, equivalent to 'teacher of the world'). His mastery was not confined to Nyāya. According to the account in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, he was also accomplished in Mīmāṃsā, the school of Vedic hermeneutics, and thoroughly familiar with the Pāṇinian grammatical tradition and epic literature, quoting the Bhagavadgītā at several points in the Tattvacintāmaṇi.

Of the achievements of Mithila, spread across the Gangetic plains of present-day Bihar and southern Nepal, V. P. Bhatta writes in the preface to his translation (2012): 'Of the six systems of Indian philosophy, the Nyāyaśāstra played an important role in the development and analysis of philosophy, logic, and epistemology in India … However, the advent of Navya-Nyāya brought a revolutionary change in the approach of Nyāya philosophy. It systematised all the Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika concepts under four heads, namely: 1) perception, 2) inference, 3) comparison, and 4) verbal testimony … The method employed in the presentation of various doctrines in the T.C. profoundly influenced philosophical writing in India over the five-hundred-year period from the thirteenth to the eighteenth century CE; nearly all writers of the śāstras adopted the T.C.'s method of presentation.' He adds: 'The importance of the work (T.C.) for philosophy, logic, and epistemology cannot be overemphasised.'

In Ben-Ami Scharfstein's A Comparative History of World Philosophy, Gaṅgeśa is placed alongside Descartes and Leibniz as one of three philosophers whose shared concern is the pursuit of certainty through the methodical application of reason. For Scharfstein, all three share a

fundamental orientation: they are logicians in the sense that they seek to understand the world by isolating and vindicating the method of reasoning, rather than its subject matter. 'Gaṅgeśa performs his task by refining an existing logical technique to secure regularity, the most reliable instrument of induction.' His work, Scharfstein writes, earned him the epithet 'the jeweller'—the maker of a jewel of thought—and its roughly three hundred pages were 'responsible for an estimated million pages of commentary'.

Potter and Bhattacharya, in the Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies (1993), put the matter simply: 'Gaṅgeśa possessed a unique genius that safely places him among the finest philosophical minds in the world.'

The Nyāya school traces its classical foundation to Gautama's Nyāya-sūtra (approximately 100 CE) and the earliest major commentary upon it by Vātsyāyana (approximately 400 CE). It is marked by a thoroughgoing realism concerning the external world and a systematic account of the pramāṇas, or valid sources of knowledge: perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), comparison (upamāna), and verbal testimony (śabda). Over roughly a millennium, commentators including Uddyotakara (about 600 CE), Vācaspati Miśra (about 950 CE), and Udayana (about 1000 CE) elaborated the system; most importantly, Udayana integrated it with the category ontology of Vaiśeṣika. Gaṅgeśa explicitly positioned himself as Udayana's follower and incorporated the seven Vaiśeṣika categories—substance (dravya), quality (guṇa), action (karma), universal (sāmānya), particularity (viśeṣa), inherence (samavāya), and absence (abhāva)—as the ontological framework of his epistemological project.

As the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy cautions, the division between 'old' Nyāya (Prācīna-Nyāya) and 'new' Nyāya (Navya-Nyāya), often said to have been inaugurated by Gaṅgeśa, was not a clean break. Development was continuous across nearly two thousand years. Nevertheless, the Tattvacintāmaṇi accomplished a qualitative change: it displaced the sūtra-commentary tradition, established an analytic vocabulary of exceptional precision, and compelled every later Naiyāyika to engage with it. Many of the technical instruments were already present in Gaṅgeśa's predecessor Maṇikaṇṭha Miśra, and the Buddhist logician Dharmakīrti (about 600 CE) had anticipated several of Gaṅgeśa's discussions of fallacies. Yet no earlier figure had synthesised and extended the tradition on so comprehensive a scale.

The full title Tattvacintāmaṇi means 'The Jewel of Reflection on Truth' (tattva, truth or reality; cintāmaṇi, a wish-fulfilling jewel of reflection, metaphorically a jewel of thought). The work is also called Pramāṇacintāmaṇi, 'The Jewel of Reflection on Knowledge'. The title is at once epistemological and aspirational: it claims to be the jewel that fulfils

the desire to understand valid knowledge. Gaṅgeśa begins with a benediction addressed to Śiva, in keeping with the Nyāya practice of maṅgalavāda, the invocation of auspiciousness, and moves immediately to the question of what pramā, or valid knowledge, is.

Book 1 — Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa (Perception). The longest and philosophically richest of the four books, it establishes a general theory of knowledge; the nature of valid and invalid cognition; an extensive phenomenology of perception in its ordinary (laukika) and extraordinary (alaukika) forms; the theory of inherence; the problem of absence; and the atomic nature of the mind. It concludes with discussions of indeterminate and determinate perception (nirvikalpaka and savikalpaka) and of anuvyavasāya, reflexive awareness.

Book 2 — Anumāna-khaṇḍa (Inference). The most technically difficult and influential book, it treats the conditions of inferential knowledge; the paramount concept of vyāpti, invariable concomitance or pervasion; the theory of upādhi, a qualifying condition of the middle term; the classification of fallacies; and inference both for oneself (svārthānumāna) and for another (parārthānumāna), including the syllogism. It also contains arguments for the existence of the self, a theistic inference (īśvarānumāna), and the possibility of liberation.

Book 3 — Upamāna-khaṇḍa (Comparison). The shortest of the four books argues that resemblance constitutes a genuinely distinct pramāṇa, conveying knowledge of a word's meaning through perceived similarity. The standard example—a traveller learns the word gavaya (a kind of wild bovine) from the description 'like a cow' and later identifies the animal in a forest—shows that knowledge by comparison is not reducible to either perception or inference.

Book 4 — Śabda-khaṇḍa (Verbal Testimony). This is an extended analysis of language as a means of knowledge, encompassing the definition of valid speech; the conditions of meaningful utterance (ākāṅkṣā/expectancy, yogyatā/semantic fitness, āsatti/proximity, and tātparya/intention); the nature of śakti (primary signifying capacity) and lakṣaṇā (secondary signification); classes of compound words; verbal affixes, roots, and prefixes; theories of word meaning; and the extensive question of Vedic injunctions. According to the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, this book contains the longest single section in the entire Tattvacintāmaṇi, devoted to lakṣaṇā, secondary meaning.

Epistemology and Logic

Truth and Error: Gaṅgeśa's Theory of Valid Cognition

The Definition of Truth (Prāmāṇyavāda)

The Potter Encyclopedia (pp. 53–54) offers a precise technical formulation of Gaṅgeśa's theory of truth as set out in the prāmāṇyavāda section of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa. Gaṅgeśa defines truth (prāmāṇya) thus: "(a) either there must be a cognition whose principal qualificand, IO, is present in that which possesses IO; or (b) there must be a cognition relating IO to something that possesses IO." In other words, a pramā (valid cognition) is a cognition (a) whose predicate term is connected with its subject term, or (b) which correctly attributes a property, IO, to an entity that actually possesses IO. The Encyclopedia observes that "Gaṅgeśa argues in support of his analysis that only when (a) or (b) is satisfied does a person act on the basis of the cognition in question. Moreover, he argues, it is the most economical account of truth." Significantly, he puts forward this analysis as a "common platform" for truth: the formulation is acceptable to schools irrespective of whether they regard validity as intrinsic (svataḥ-prāmāṇya) or extrinsic (parataḥ-prāmāṇya).

Scharfstein's comparative perspective illuminates the importance of this epistemological position: "Gaṅgeśa is committed to the Nyāya belief in a real, external world, a real, immaterial self, and the distinctive power of perception and inference, each assisting the other, to reach certainty." Contrary to the Mīmāṃsaka thesis of self-validation, according to which each cognition establishes its own validity upon arising, Gaṅgeśa maintains that verification requires a second-order act of inference. Thus he argues against the sceptic: "Your argument against inference depends upon inference. When you say that inference is not a means of knowledge, you mean that the proposition that inference is such a means is doubtful or false. But that it is doubtful or false cannot be known by perception."

The Pratibandhaka–Pratibaddha Relation and Epistemic Logic

The Potter Encyclopedia draws attention to a major feature of the Navya-Nyāya theory of cognition with philosophical implications for the theory of justification: the pratibandhaka–pratibaddha relation, that between an inhibitor and what is inhibited. This is not merely a psychological rule about the impossibility of attending to two things at once. It is a rule of epistemic logic determined by the objects of cognition. While a cognition of P persists as a conscious act, it prevents a cognition of the absence of P from arising—not simply because the two compete psychologically, but through logical necessity: "The presence of one act prevents the production

of the other, so that they can never be co-present, not even for an instant." This relation matters to the theory of doubt and its resolution through tarka (suppositional reasoning).

The Encyclopedia explains how this principle addresses the problem of induction, particularly the removal of doubt about vyāpti: "The Nyāya doctrine is that the decisive factor here is the presence or absence of doubt in the thinker … Whoever doubts that the reason (hetu) might be inconstant cannot, while that doubt remains, know the pervasion between the reason and the probandum. The question is: is this a psychological rule? Nyāya distinguishes two kinds of obstruction … It is concerned with another kind of obstruction, in which one cognitive state is obstructed by another because of their objects. What prevents someone from knowing a particular pervasion is not the structure of his mind but the fact that he has a particular doubt." This is epistemic logic, not psychology.

The Theory of Perception

Perception and the Self

Gaṅgeśa's account of perception is embedded in a rich metaphysics of mind and self. Scharfstein explains: "In Nyāya theory the mind is an unconscious inner sense or cause, conveying successive sensations from the external senses to the conscious self … The mind can connect with only one sense at a time. This limitation suggests that the mind is extremely minute, the size of an atom … It is the self that is responsible for memory … Without a permanent, mediating self, how could the past perception of blue later be responsible for the memory of that same blue? Without the self and the memories it preserves, how could one explain that something I saw with my left eye is subsequently recognised by my right eye?" The self cannot be reduced to body, senses, or mind; it is the distinctive substratum of consciousness and the locus of memory, recognition, and synthesis across the senses.

Indeterminate and Determinate Perception

Gaṅgeśa's distinction between nirvikalpaka (indeterminate) and savikalpaka (determinate) perception is one of his philosophically most important contributions. Scharfstein describes the indeterminate phase as concept-free awareness: it is not yet associated with names, universals, and the like; it does not apprehend something as qualified in a particular way and is wholly without predicates. What follows is structured, relational, qualified awareness—awareness informed by concepts. We know fully what we experience when we apprehend it as a complex of universal and particular, and can say, almost triumphantly, "Pot!" or "This is a pot."

Both sources explain the philosophical need to posit indeterminate perception. In the Potter Encyclopedia's treatment of Gaṅgeśa's example, if universals or general properties are conceived (as they sometimes are in Western philosophy) as possessing instances rather than inhering in particulars, one mistranslates an Indian position that is neither Platonic nor Aristotelian. A qualifier (viśeṣaṇa) is related to the qualificand (viśeṣya or dharmin). When one perceives a pot, the universal potness (ghaṭatva) is the qualifier, while the individual pot is the qualificand. Indeterminate perception registers this qualificand and qualifier separately before any relational predication. This helps explain how we can encounter a kind of thing for the first time and yet classify it correctly.

Anuvyavasāya (Subsequent Cognition)

The theory of anuvyavasāya—a cognition that takes an earlier cognition as its object—is philosophically central to Gaṅgeśa's account of verification. Scharfstein distinguishes "simple awareness" from "self-reflective awareness or subsequent cognition, expressed in words such as 'I am aware of this'." The Potter Encyclopedia specifies its introspective structure: "A cognition can produce a disposition; indeed, a disposition can arise only from an act … An introspective act is only one step behind the act that forms its content. In the waking state, no interval is experienced between the two cognitions. When the earlier cognition enters its second temporal phase, the later cognition arises and replaces it." Gaṅgeśa argues that anuvyavasāya is infallible with respect to the intentional structure of the extended cognition, though not with respect to its truth.

Illusion: Anyathākhyātivāda

Anyathākhyātivāda—the doctrine that illusion consists in becoming aware of one thing "as other than it is"—occupies one of the longest sections of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa. Scharfstein explains: "When a rope is mistaken for a snake, some genuine knowledge is present: knowledge of the 'thisness' of the object lying on the ground. The false part of perceptual cognition depends on a partial or complete identification of what is actually seen with an object of another kind … The evidence showing that my perceptual cognition is right or wrong as a whole is the success or failure of actions following from it: only a snake, not a rope, actually bites." Following Udayana, Gaṅgeśa distinguishes an initial apprehension, which cannot be mistaken, from a later, structured cognition in which error is possible. The content of illusory cognition is always traceable to previous genuine cognitions: in the shell–silver illusion, the presentation of silverness derives from an earlier real perception of silver. Gaṅgeśa's theory of error is therefore firmly realist.

The Theory of Inference: The Problem of Vyāpti and Its Resolution

Vyāpti (Invariable Concomitance): What Is at Stake Philosophically

Gaṅgeśa's greatest technical achievement is his decisive account of vyāpti, or invariable concomitance ("pervasion"). Much is at stake: vyāpti is the relation underlying every inference, and an adequate definition of it is required to distinguish genuine inference from pseudo-inference. Scharfstein explains the underlying idea: "For Gaṅgeśa, pervasion means the unconditional relation arising from the nature of a reason or sign, as in the pervasion of smokiness by fireness, which in this instance may be explained through the nature of fire and the nature of smoke produced by fire. To call knowledge unconditional also means that we know of nothing that would make the relation accidental."

Before reaching his final definition, Gaṅgeśa considers and rejects numerous earlier attempts. Scharfstein notes that he discards "twenty-one proposals" (the monograph by Jha 'Ashok' counts twenty-four, including subtypes). The Potter Encyclopedia offers the most technically exact account. The first definition considered—avyabhicāra, non-deviation—fails because it "does not apply in cases where the probandum (sādhya) is not locus-pervasive." Each subsequent definition founders on particular counterexamples, especially that of "monkeys in a tree," where the ascribed property is not pervasive throughout the locus. The final, decisive definition is given as follows: "Pervasion is the co-presence of property 10 (the reason) with property B (the probandum), where B is not qualified by the delimitor of the counterpositive of an absolute absence that shares a locus with 10 but does not share a locus with its counterpositive." Scharfstein gives a simplified version attributed to Gokūpa: "A is pervaded by B if and only if A shares a locus with B in such a manner that B is not one of the things which, as a class, are wholly absent from any locus of A."

Resolving Doubt about Vyāpti: Tarka

The Potter Encyclopedia provides the fullest treatment of how tarka—suppositional or non-demonstrative reasoning—works in removing doubt about pervasion. The Nyāya doctrine is that doubt about vyāpti acts as an inhibitor of the cognition of vyāpti. Tarka does not itself confer knowledge of pervasion; it removes the doubt obstructing that cognition. In the smoke–fire example, the formal structure of a tarka runs as follows: "If smoke deviated from fire, it would not be produced by fire. But smoke is produced by fire. Therefore smoke cannot deviate from fire." Doubt is thus resolved not by adding fresh inductive evidence but by showing that maintaining the doubt leads to a consequence that both sides regard as

false. Hence Gaṅgeśa agrees with Udayana's pragmatic argument against the sceptic: "When he wishes to produce smoke, he always lights a fire … The sceptic's own action renders his doubt pointless."

The Encyclopedia draws an important distinction from Western philosophy of induction: "The Nyāya doctrine is that in some cases a single observation is enough, while in others innumerable observations may still not be enough, to generate knowledge of pervasion. The decisive factor is the presence or absence of doubt in the thinker … Although whether doubt exists is entirely subjective, the Nyāya doctrine is not psychological. Nyāya asserts a universal rule: whoever doubts that a reason (hetu) might be inconstant cannot know the pervasion between reason and probandum while that doubt persists." Moreover, Navya-Nyāya differs from the Western tendency to justify induction by invoking causation or the uniformity of nature: "According to Nyāya, it is enough to know that two things are invariably concomitant; we need not attempt to provide a reason for that fact."

Upādhi (Additional Condition) and Fallacious Reasons

The concept of an upādhi—a qualifying or additional condition—is Gaṅgeśa's instrument for identifying and preventing spurious inferences. An upādhi is a property pervading the probandum (every instance of the sādhya has the upādhi-property) but not pervading the reason (some instances of the hetu lack that property). Where such a condition is present, the seeming pervasion of the probandum by the reason breaks down: there are instances of the reason without the probandum because the upādhi-property is missing in them. A classical Navya-Nyāya example is the apparent inference, "A smoke-producing thing is fire-producing because it is a product," blocked by the condition "being wet fuel": wet fuel is smoke-producing but not fire-producing. The discussion of upādhi (upādhivāda) in the Anumāna-khaṇḍa spans numerous subsections and is among the most technically difficult discussions in the entire Tattvacintāmaṇi.

The Five Fallacious Reasons (Hetvābhāsas)

The Hetvābhāsa-prakaraṇa is the last major section of the Anumāna-khaṇḍa. It distinguishes five apparent reasons: (1) savyabhicāra (inconstant or irregular—the reason occurs both in similar and dissimilar instances); (2) viruddha (contradictory—the reason proves the opposite of the intended conclusion); (3) satpratipakṣa (counterbalanced by an equally strong opposing reason); (4) asiddha (unestablished—the presence, nature, or pervasion of the reason is doubtful); and (5) bādhita (already defeated—the conclusion contradicts something previously known). Navya-Nyāya treatment of these fallacies goes considerably beyond the five original

categories in the Nyāya-sūtra, particularly in dividing savyabhicāra into sādhāraṇa (common or general) and asādhāraṇa (uncommon or particular) forms and treating anaikāntika as a subsidiary class.

Three Philosophical Inferences

Beyond technical logic, Gaṅgeśa advances three controversial philosophical inferences. His proof of the self (ātman) takes the form of a kevala-vyatireki (exclusively negative) inference: "Every living body has a self, because every living body has breath, unlike a pot." His theistic inference maintains that the earth and other effects have a conscious maker as their efficient cause, because they are effects, like a pot and unlike atoms. His inference establishing the possibility of liberation (mukti-sādhaka-anumāna) employs the analogy of an extinguished lamp to argue that suffering, being a continuously produced attribute, can in principle be brought wholly to an end. These three arguments do as much to exhibit the distinctive Navya-Nyāya apparatus of inference—including kevalānvayi and kevala-vyatireki inference, upādhi, and tarka—as they do to establish their metaphysical conclusions.

The Theories of Upamāna (Analogy) and Śabda (Verbal Testimony)

For Gaṅgeśa, upamāna (analogy or comparison) is strictly the means of knowledge by which one learns the relation between a word and its referent through perceived similarity. The standard illustration is this: a traveller is told that a gavaya, a large bovine animal, resembles a cow. On encountering the animal in the forest, the traveller comes to know, "This creature, which resembles a cow, is what the word 'gavaya' denotes." The product of this means of knowledge (upamiti) is knowledge of the word–object relation (sādhya-sādhana-sambandha, as given in the source). Gaṅgeśa maintains that upamāna is irreducible to both perception and inference. The crucial step is that the forest-dweller's statement, "A gavaya resembles a cow," does more than convey a description (which could give only perceptual or verbal knowledge of a fact). It functions as a meaning-bearing utterance that, together with the listener's direct encounter with the animal, produces new knowledge of the relation between word and meaning.

Śabda: The Irreducibility of Testimony

The Śabda-khaṇḍa defends verbal testimony as a fourth, irreducible pramāṇa. Against the reductionist claim that testimony is merely inference from a speaker's reliability, Gaṅgeśa argues that the proposed inferential chain itself presupposes linguistic understanding. One cannot even establish the premise "This speaker says P" without first

comprehending the utterance, which is already a verbal operation. The distinctive linguistic mechanism of this pramāṇa—ākāṅkṣā (syntactic expectancy), yogyatā (semantic compatibility), āsatti (temporal proximity), and tātparya (speaker's intention)—differs from any inferential procedure.

The Tātparyavāda section presents Gaṅgeśa's innovation: the trigger for lakṣaṇā (secondary meaning) is not, as commonly assumed, violation of yogyatā (semantic compatibility), but violation of the overall syntactic-semantic connection (anvaya). In the well-known example "gaṅgāyāṃ ghoṣaḥ" ("a settlement on the Ganges"), secondary meaning is required not because the terms "Ganges" and "settlement" are semantically incompatible in themselves, but because the construction as a whole cannot be coherently interpreted by taking the river's water as the primary referent.

Vardhamāna Upādhyāya: The Immediate Successor

According to a tradition cited by N. S. Rāmānujatātācārya, Vardhamāna was Gaṅgeśa's eldest son by his first wife and the primary disseminator of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. He was also a philosopher of considerable standing in his own right. His works include the Kusumāñjali-prakāśa, Kiraṇāvalī-prakāśa, Tātparya-pariśuddhi (also known as Nyāyanibandha-prakāśa), Ātmatattvaviveka-prakāśa, Śrīvallabhācārya's Nyāyalīlāvatī-prakāśa, Khaṇḍanakhaṇḍakhādya-prakāśa, and a commentary on Keśava Miśra's Tarkabhāṣā called Prakāśa. Another text independently attributed to him is the Nyāyasūtravṛtti entitled Anvīkṣaṇīyatattvabodha.

Unlike his father, Vardhamāna deliberately wrote his commentaries under the banner "as my father says" (the Sanskrit wording is given in the source as "asmatputruccaraṇāstu"), reading the writings of Udayana and Śrīvallabha through the doctrines of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. He composed Prakāśa commentaries on nearly every major philosophical work of his time. The Devānanda Pañjī calls him an "upayakāraka"—one who renders things useful. As Dr Kiśoranātha Jhā is quoted as explaining, although Vardhamāna did not write a direct commentary on the Tattvacintāmaṇi (perhaps because his father was alive when the work began to circulate and Vardhamāna considered such a commentary premature), "his manner in all his commentaries is to cite the Tattvacintāmaṇi as a relevant reference, so that its principles are always reflected."

The Commentary Tradition (Vyākhyā-paramparā)

The tradition of commentary on the Tattvacintāmaṇi constitutes one of the most extensive accumulations of scholarship in the Sanskrit intellectual world.

The Pakṣadhara–Raghunātha–Navadvīpa Axis

A decisive moment in the popularisation of the Tattvacintāmaṇi was the composition of the Āloka by Pakṣadhara Upādhyāya (also known as Jayadeva Miśra, fifteenth century). Vāsudeva Sārvabhauma, the celebrated scholar of Navadvīpa, initially came to study with Pakṣadhara Miśra, a pupil of Vāsudeva's maternal uncle Harimiśra. Pakṣadhara, however, told him to return and study first under Harimiśra. Vāsudeva went back and later sent his own pupil, Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, to study in Mithila. When Raghunātha arrived to study the Tattvacintāmaṇi with Pakṣadhara, the story goes that Pakṣadhara asked him who Indra was—a trick question concerning perception through a generic characteristic: could an entire succession of Indras be perceived at once through a universal "Indrahood"? Raghunātha's answer, distinguishing the class of two-eyed beings from that of three-eyed beings, so impressed Pakṣadhara that he declared him a Śiromaṇi, a "crest-jewel" among logicians, even before formal recognition. The exchange exemplifies the dazzling dialectical culture of Navya-Nyāya.

Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's Dīdhiti is the most important secondary work in the Navya-Nyāya tradition, eclipsing the influence of other commentaries. Based in Navadvīpa, Raghunātha developed Gaṅgeśa's insights into a systematic framework that has continued to be studied into the present. The Dīdhiti itself attracted commentaries from scholars across the subcontinent: Rāmakṛṣṇa Bhaṭṭācārya (Līlāvatī), Raghunātha Vidyālaṅkāra (Dīdhiti-pratibimba), Kṛṣṇadāsa Sārvabhauma (Prasāriṇī), Mathurānātha Tarkavāgīśa (Rahasya), Jagadīśa Tarkālaṅkāra (Jāgadīśī), Gadādhara Bhaṭṭācārya (Gādādhara), and Rudra-Nyāyavācaspati (Sārasaṅgraha), among many others.

The Maithil Tradition

In Mithila itself, the commentary tradition began with Vardhamāna's engagement with the Tattvacintāmaṇi through his Prakāśa commentaries; it continued with Pakṣadhara's Āloka, which helped kindle the Navadvīpa tradition, and expanded through the Dūṣaṇoddhāra of Pakṣadhara's pupil Narahari Upādhyāya, the Dīpikā of Pakṣadhara's son Mādhava Miśra, and many Maithil treatises devoted to particular topics. Internal scholarly disputes between the Āloka line (Pakṣadhara's lineage, followed by Yajñapati) and the Dūṣaṇoddhāra line (Narahari's lineage)—apart from interpretive disagreements over the upādhi-siddha and savyabhicāra sections—show how the two schools directed the internal development of Navya-Nyāya over the centuries.

Known Commentators: A Selection

Among twenty-three known commentators, in addition to those already mentioned, the most significant are Paṭanābha Miśra (Prakāśa), Gokulanāthopādhyāya (Raśmicakra/Cakraraśmi), Gopīnātha Ṭhākura (Maṇisāra), Vāsudeva Miśra (Nyāyasiddhāntasāra/Dīpti), Mādhava Miśra, son of Pakṣadhara (Dīpikā), Mādhava Miśra, son of Khāntara (Mādhavī), Hīrādāsa Nyāyālaṅkāra (Prakāśa on the Anumāna-khaṇḍa), Kaṇāda Tarkavāgīśa (Ṭīkā), Bhavānanda Siddhāntavāgīśa (Bhavānandī), Rāmānuja Dīkṣita (Darpaṇa), Śrīkaṇṭha Dīkṣita (Ṭīkā), Hanumad-Bhaṭṭa (Vākyārtha-dīpikā), Candra-Nārāyaṇa Bhaṭṭa (Anugama), Rājacūḍāmaṇi Makhin (Darpaṇa), and Dharmarājavīrendra (Tarkacūḍāmaṇi).

Gaṅgeśa and Mithila's Civilisational Heritage: The Videha Perspective

Videha magazine (Videha Web Archive, ISSN 2229-547X), described here as the first fortnightly Maithili e-magazine and as having operated continuously since about 2000 CE, is a major digital repository of Mithila's living cultural heritage. Its library, the Videha Pothi Archive, makes hundreds of texts available in PDF: from the Bauddhagānapada—early Bengali–Maithili Siddha compositions preserved in Haraprasad Shastri's 1907 edition—and collections of Vidyāpati, to modern Maithili fiction, poetry, drama, criticism, women's writing, Dalit literature, folk scholarship, and linguistic research.

The pañjī archive—more than eleven thousand palm-leaf records collected, scanned, and catalogued in twenty-two volumes by Preeti Thakur—is, according to this account, accessible through Videha and constitutes the single most important primary source for the social history of the Maithil Brahmin scholarly community to which Gaṅgeśa belonged. The genealogical documents of the pañjī system record his name, gotra, ancestral affiliation (mūla), family relationships, and his ancestral village, "Chādana." Without the pañjī tradition—which the Videha archive actively digitises and preserves—much of what is known about Gaṅgeśa's life would be lost.

Ashish Anchinhar's History of Maithili Web Journalism and Preeti Karan Setu Banhal ("Redefining Maithili"), both available through the Videha archive, document a parallel literary movement that seeks to recover and celebrate Maithili folk, Dalit, and women's literary voices alongside the Sanskrit philosophical canon. Gaṅgeśa's exceptionally abstract and technical achievement stands at one end of the full spectrum of Maithili civilisation; at the other stand the folk songs of the Bauddhagānapada, the humorous tales of Gonu Jha, the Salhes epic tradition, and the modern Maithili ghazal tradition promoted by Anchinhar's Anchinhar Akhar.

The Videha project's insistence on bringing all these together—the Mahāmahopādhyāya and the folk poet, the Tattvacintāmaṇi and the Caryāpadas—is its most significant cultural and political statement. Gaṅgeśa belongs to all of Mithila, not merely to its Sanskrit elite.

Radhakrishna Chaudhary's History of Mithila, Jayakant Mishra's A History of Maithili Literature, Volume I, and Upendra Thakur's History of Mithila—all available through the Videha archive—provide the broader historical and literary setting for Gaṅgeśa. They place him within a civilisation that valued both the most technically exact philosophy and the most intimate folk expression, the most rigorous logic and the gentlest devotional poetry. The Mithila that produced the Tattvacintāmaṇi also produced Vidyāpati's songs. It is the continuing existence of this entire civilisational inheritance, now digitally preserved through Videha, that gives Gaṅgeśa's work its fullest meaning.

Conclusion: An Enduring Achievement

By any measure, Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi is among the ten or fifteen most consequential works in the twenty-five-hundred-year history of Indian philosophy. It displaced every earlier Nyāya treatise as the principal object of study and commentary; gave India's logical tradition its most precise analytical vocabulary; extended the influence of Nyāya into every branch of Sanskrit learning, including grammar, jurisprudence, medicine, and aesthetics; and created the Navya-Nyāya school, whose commentators and subcommentators form one of the largest bodies of sustained, systematic philosophical writing in any tradition in the world.

Born in Mithila, the son of Paṇḍita Girīśvara, bearing the ritual name Gaṅgeśvara and the everyday name Gaṅgeśa, honoured with the title Mahāmahopādhyāya by a tradition that reserved it for mastery of Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, and Dharmaśāstra, active during the reign of Harisiṃhadeva—the most culturally accomplished of the Karṇāṭa rulers—and perhaps resident in the village of Chādanā/Chājaṃ, now near the Turkī railway station in Muzaffarpur district: this is the biographical outline emerging, in the author's account, from the combined testimony of the pañjī records, internal evidence of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, and externally dated contemporaries.

Extended Note on Biographical Evidence

The Author's Actual Name

What was the author's actual name? The answer offered here is that Gaṅgeśvara was his formal or ritual name, while Gaṅgeśa was his everyday or familiar name. This is said to be decisively established by two kinds of

evidence. First, Gaṅgeśa himself uses the name "Gaṅgeśa" in the first person in the maṅgalācaraṇa (opening invocation) of the Tattvacintāmaṇi: "gaṅgeśa-stute mitena vacase śrī-tattva-cintāmaṇim." Second, his son and principal disciple Vardhamāna explicitly pays homage in the Kiraṇāvalī-prakāśa to his father and teacher as "Gaṅgeśvara": "nyāyāmbhoja-pataṅgāya mīmāṃsā-pāradṛśvane / gaṅgeśvarāya gurave pitre bhavate namaḥ." The name Gaṅgeśvara also appears in the Kusumāñjali-prakāśa.

The genealogical pañjī records connect both names to the same biographical locations and relations, while the pañjī-prabandha describes the village "Chādana" in the following words: "chādanaṃ tattvacintāmaṇi-kāraka mahāmahopādhyāya paramaguruḥ gaṅgeśvaraḥ."

Birthplace

Gaṅgeśa's birthplace has generated considerable scholarly controversy. Various scholars have proposed different villages: (1) Mangrauni (or Mangalwani), a village in Madhubani district; (2) Kiryan (also Kiriyam), twelve miles south-east of Darbhanga; (3) Chakauti; and (4) Chājaṃ (historical Chādana), now close to the Turkī railway station in Muzaffarpur district. The pañjī records, presented here as the most authoritative evidence on these questions, consistently describe Gaṅgeśa as "Chādana-sambhūta"—a native of Chādana/Chājaṃ.

The Tibetan traveller Dharmasvāmin, who visited Mithila during the reign of the Karṇāṭa king Rāmasiṃhadeva (1234 CE), mentioned a place called "To-ki," near which followers of Jainism and Buddhism were numerous. This "To-ki" has been identified with present-day "Turkī," near which Gaṅgeśa's village of Chājaṃ is situated.

Gotra and Family

Gaṅgeśa belonged to the Kāśyapa gotra. In the pañjī system his mūla—his ancestral village affiliation—was "Sirisabe-Chādana," meaning that he belonged to the Sirisab ancestral line and, more particularly, its Chādana branch. The pañjī records describe him as "Sirisabe-Chādana mūla," of the Kāśyapa gotra. His father's name was Girīśvara Upādhyāya, who, according to these records, died five years before Gaṅgeśa's birth.

Certain pañjī records indicate that his formal name was Gaṅgeśvara and his commonly used name Gaṅgeśa. He had two wives: by the first, a daughter and his eldest son Vardhamāna; by the second, sons named Sūpana and Hara. The same records are cited as establishing that Vardhamāna's daughter married into the Khaṇḍavālā mūla of the Śāṇḍilya gotra (in the lineage of Śivanātha, son of Viśvanātha); that the marriages of Vardhamāna's son Candraka–Balabhadra–Śobhā were with Chādana-

origin families; that Sūpana's daughter married into the Jijivāla mūla of the Śāṇḍilya gotra; and that Sūpana himself married into the Bhaṇḍārīsamaya mūla.

Part II · A Detailed Examination of Epistemology

It was the discipline of epistemological necessity—Gaṅgeśa's refusal to discuss anything other than the nature and conditions of valid cognition—that gave the Tattvacintāmaṇi its world-changing force. The Navya-Nyāya school that it initiated trained the Indian philosophical tradition in precision of thought and rigour of reasoning; it served as a "touchstone of intellect and talent, a touchstone of gold." Gaṅgeśa belongs to the philosophical heritage of Mithila, of India, and of the world.

Videha magazine's continuing digital preservation of Mithila's intellectual and literary inheritance—from the pañjī records that register Gaṅgeśa's village, gotra, and family to contemporary creative writing in Maithili that sustains the civilisation which helped to shape him—is, in a genuine sense, a living institutional successor to the tradition he embodied. By archiving texts ranging from Vidyāpati to Dalit women's poetry, it carries forward the same civilisational commitment to rigorous thought and freedom of expression that, seven centuries ago, produced one of the masterpieces of world philosophy.

Epistemological Contributions

The Nature of Valid Cognition (Pramā)

Gaṅgeśa's epistemology begins with the definition of pramā: valid cognition is the cognition of a thing as it is—more precisely, a cognition in which a universal nature genuinely inheres in the object that is its subject. Knowing a piece of silver as silver is valid cognition because "silverness" actually inheres in that individual piece of silver. By contrast, apprehending mother-of-pearl (a shell) as silver is apramā, invalid cognition or anyathākhyāti ("apprehending a thing otherwise than it is"), because silverness does not inhere in the shell.

Gaṅgeśa advances a position that contemporary Western philosophy might identify as reliabilist, indeed as infallibilist-externalist: a genuine source of knowledge (pramāṇa) never misleads. Only an apparent source (pramāṇābhāsa) does so. The sources themselves—perception, inference, comparison, and testimony—are defined factively: illusion and error arise not from a genuine source but from something masquerading as one. This permits Gaṅgeśa to uphold both fallibility (we may be mistaken on any particular occasion) and the infallibility of a source (a genuine source, when operative, invariably yields truth).

Validation: Parataḥ-prāmāṇya (Extrinsic Validity)

A central debate in Indian epistemology concerns whether the validity of cognition is self-certifying (svataḥ-prāmāṇya, as held by the Mīmāṃsakas) or requires external verification (parataḥ-prāmāṇya). Gaṅgeśa argues for the latter. A cognition is taken initially to be valid—we naturally and

spontaneously accept newly presented information as true—but this prima-facie acceptance is defeasible. When doubt arises, further inferential verification is required, either through identification of the source of cognition or through practical success in action. The Mīmāṃsaka claim that cognition certifies itself cannot, Gaṅgeśa contends, account for the phenomenological fact of doubt: if every cognition certified itself as inherently true at the moment it arose, we could never doubt a genuine perception; plainly, however, we do.

The Definition of Perception

Gaṅgeśa builds upon the original formulation in Akṣapāda's Nyāya-sūtra but substantially refines it. Against the accepted definition—knowledge arising from contact between a sense organ and its object, non-deviating, and either determinate or indeterminate—he argues that it is both too broad (including memory and inference of the self) and too narrow (excluding divine perception). His preferred distinguishing characteristic is this: perception is immediate cognition whose instrumental cause is not another cognition. That differentiates it from inference, whose instrumental cause is reflection upon premises, and from testimony, whose instrumental cause is comprehension of a statement.

Ordinary and Extraordinary Perception

Following the Nyāya tradition, Gaṅgeśa distinguishes two broad classes of perceptual contact between a sense organ and its object. Ordinary contact (laukika-sannikarṣa) occurs in six ways: (1) saṃyoga, conjunction—as between the eye and a pot; (2) saṃyukta-samavāya, inherence in something conjoined—as between the eye and the colour of the pot; (3) saṃyukta-samaveta-samavāya, inherence in what inheres in a conjoined object—as between the eye and the universal of colour; (4) samavāya, inherence—as between the ear and sound inhering in ether; (5) samaveta-samavāya, inherence in what inheres—as between the ear and soundhood, the universal of sound; and (6) viśeṣaṇatā, qualification—as between the eye and the absence of a pot on the floor.

Extraordinary contact (alaukika-sannikarṣa) has three forms: (1) sāmānya-lakṣaṇa, perceiving the universal nature of smoke and, through it, instances of smoke in every time and place; (2) jñāna-lakṣaṇa, an "indirect perception" recognised in Western psychology, as when the sight of sandalwood, by activating memory, leads us to apprehend its fragrance; and (3) yogaja, the perceptual power of advanced ascetics.

Among Gaṅgeśa's most philosophically sophisticated contributions is his distinction between nirvikalpaka (indeterminate, non-conceptual) and savikalpaka (determinate, conceptual) perception. Nirvikalpaka perception is the initial, extraordinary, concept-free moment in which an individual object and its universal nature are registered separately, before being joined—"pot alone" or "potness alone," without relational qualification. Savikalpaka

perception is the subsequent, concept-laden awareness of a qualificand by means of a qualifier: "This is a pot," where potness is predicated of this object.

Gaṅgeśa employs a famous thought experiment: a child encountering a cow for the first time, he argues, can grasp cowness through an indeterminate apprehension of the qualifier and correctly say "That is a cow," without a previous experience of a cow. This addresses how a concept can arise in perception without presupposing prior possession of that very concept—a difficulty analytic epistemology addresses through the idea of "non-doxastic" or "non-assertoric" perceptual states.

Gaṅgeśa's theory of anuvyavasāya—a perception that takes a preceding cognition as its object—is his answer to the question of how one knows what one knows. He argues that such self-directed perception is infallible with respect to the intentional content (viṣayatā) of the earlier cognition, though not with respect to its truth. By experiencing a perceptual awareness and identifying it as perceptual (rather than inferential or memorial), the subject obtains a secure basis for verification or questioning. This theory places Gaṅgeśa's epistemology in productive dialogue with Western discussions of introspection, higher-order knowledge, and self-consciousness.

The Theory of Inference (Anumāna)

Invariable Concomitance (Vyāpti)

Gaṅgeśa's greatest achievement in the theory of inference is his definitive definition of vyāpti (invariable concomitance, often rendered "pervasion" or "natural entailment"). Vyāpti grounds an inference: the fact that smoke is pervaded by fire (wherever there is smoke, there is fire) licenses the inference of fire on a mountain from the smoke observed there. The challenge is to define vyāpti so that it (1) handles ordinary inferences, (2) includes purely affirmative inferences for which there is no negative instance of the probandum, and (3) escapes the problem of an upādhi, a condition that restricts the middle term.

After examining and rejecting twenty-four earlier definitions—including those advanced under the designations "Lion" and "Tiger" (siṃha-vyāghrokta-vyāpti-lakṣaṇa)—Gaṅgeśa arrives at his siddhānta-lakṣaṇa, his final definition: vyāpti is the coexistence of the reason (hetu) and the probandum (sādhya), unqualified by the nature of the counterpositive of that absolute absence which (a) occurs in a locus shared with the reason but (b) occurs in a different locus with respect to that counterpositive. Vidyābhūṣaṇa's introduction supplies an accessible summary of this extended dialectic, complete with its celebrated circular diagrams of smoke and fire, the nameable and the knowable, trees and monkeys, and other examples used to illustrate successive provisional and final definitions.

The Syllogism and Inference for Others (Parārthānumāna)

Gaṅgeśa analyses inference under two forms. Svārthānumāna (inference for oneself) is the cognitive process through which a person arrives at inferential knowledge. Having repeatedly seen smoke accompanied by fire in kitchens and sacrificial halls, the person observes smoke on a mountain, recalls the relation of pervasion, and reaches the knowledge that the mountain has fire. The decisive mental event is parāmarśa, reflection upon the sign: the cognition that "smoke, which is invariably concomitant with fire, exists on this mountain." This is the cause of anumiti, the inferential conclusion.

Parārthānumāna (inference for another) is the demonstration of one's inference through a five-membered syllogism: (1) pratijñā (proposition) —"This mountain has fire"; (2) hetu (reason)—"because it has smoke"; (3) udāharaṇa (example)—"whatever has smoke has fire, as in a kitchen"; (4) upanaya (application)—"this mountain too has smoke"; and (5) nigamana (conclusion)—"therefore this mountain has fire." The syllogism elicits in the listener a "reflection upon the sign" (parāmarśa), which issues in inferential knowledge.

Fallacious Reasons (Hetvābhāsa)

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of hetvābhāsa (literally, the "semblance of a reason") is, in the words of a scholar cited by Vidyābhūṣaṇa, "one of the wonders of the world in the field of intellectual achievement." Five types of defective reasons are distinguished: (1) savyabhicāra (inconstant or deviating), a reason present in both similar (sapakṣa) and dissimilar (vipakṣa) cases; (2) viruddha (contradictory), a reason that establishes the opposite of what is to be proved; (3) satpratipakṣita (counterbalanced by an equally strong counter-reason), a reason met by an inference of equal force; (4) asiddha (unestablished), a reason whose presence in its locus, its own nature, or its pervasion is unestablished; and (5) bādhita (contradicted or already defeated), a reason leading to a conclusion already refuted by another means of knowledge.

Beyond technical logic, Gaṅgeśa advances three controversial inferences. The proof of the self (ātman) takes the form of an exclusively negative inference (kevala-vyatireki): "Every living body possesses a self, because every living body possesses vital breath, unlike a pot." His theistic inference argues: "The earth and things like it have a conscious maker as their efficient cause, because they are products, like pots and unlike atoms." The proof of the possibility of liberation (mokṣa) employs a complex inference through the analogy of a lamp going out, arguing that suffering, being a continuous quality existing only as an effect, can in principle be completely extinguished. All three arguments are demonstrations of the inferential system—with its distinctive treatment of upādhi, tarka (hypothetical reasoning), and positive and negative examples—as well as substantive metaphysical or soteriological theses.

The Theory of Comparison (Upamāna)

For Gaṅgeśa, upamāna, comparison or analogy, is strictly the source of knowledge through which a person learns the relation between a word and what it denotes. The standard example is of someone who, having been told that a gavaya (an animal resembling a bison) is like a cow, later encounters the animal in a forest and identifies it as a gavaya: the means of that recognition is knowledge through similarity. Gaṅgeśa holds that this knowledge is genuinely irreducible. It cannot be traced back to perception (which cannot perceive a relation extending over instances beyond the present example) or to inference (which requires knowledge of a vyāpti, while no such pervasion is available here). The operation (vyāpāra) of upamāna consists in recollection of the elder's instructive utterance; its result (upamiti) is knowledge of the relation between the name and the named.

The Theory of Testimony (Śabda)

Language as an Irreducible Means of Knowledge

Following the Nyāya-sūtra (1.1.7), Gaṅgeśa accepts that verbal testimony is the true statement of a reliable expert (āpta-vākya). Against the Yogācāra Buddhists, who deny language's capacity for truth, and against the Vaiśeṣikas, who wish to reduce verbal knowledge to inference, Gaṅgeśa argues that testimony works through a distinctive linguistic mechanism. The listener's knowledge arises not from the inference, "This speaker knows and intends to tell the truth," but from the immediate comprehension of words joined into a meaningful whole—a process analytically distinct from both perception and inference.

The Conditions of Verbal Knowledge

Gaṅgeśa identifies four sentential conditions that must be fulfilled for an utterance to produce verbal knowledge: (1) ākāṅkṣā, syntactic expectancy—the requirement that each word needs others to produce connected meaning; (2) yogyatā, semantic fitness—the absence of a legitimate obstacle to understanding; (3) āsatti, proximity—the words must be uttered without excessive intervals; and (4) tātparya, the speaker's intention to convey a particular meaning. Gaṅgeśa's innovation is to reinterpret the trigger of lakṣaṇā (secondary or indirect meaning), not as a violation of yogyatā, as commonly assumed, but as a failure of anvaya, the overall constructive connection—a subtle and more precise criterion.

Śakti (Denotative Power) and Lakṣaṇā (Secondary Meaning)

The chapter on testimony culminates in a rich theory of linguistic meaning. Every word possesses śakti, the capacity to evoke recollection of its referent, acquired through divine will (for primary or permanent denotative power) or through human will (for technical or contingent denotative power). A word's referent is always an individual qualified by its universal, the two

being inseparable in ordinary cognition. Where the primary referent cannot be reconciled with the sentence's connected meaning, lakṣaṇā, secondary signification, operates and directs the listener towards a related meaning: thus "gaṅgāyāṃ ghoṣaḥ" ("a settlement on the Ganges") indicates the riverbank rather than the river's water. Gaṅgeśa's defence of lakṣaṇā as an economical interpretive device, against those who would reduce all secondary meaning to primary reference or a multiplicity of meanings, is among the most technically ingenious arguments in the Tattvacintāmaṇi.

Metaphysical Commitments

Gaṅgeśa's epistemological project is grounded in a robust realist ontology inherited from Udayana's synthesis of Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika. Seven categories—substance (dravya), quality (guṇa), action (karman), universal (sāmānya), particularity (viśeṣa), inherence (samavāya), and absence (abhāva)—provide the metaphysical furniture of his theory of knowledge. Cognitions and other mental occurrences are considered real and intersubjectively knowable. Universals are real recurrent properties qualifying both substances and their qualities; inherence is the "metaphysical glue" that binds qualities and universals to their substrates in a relation that admits of no further analysis.

Gaṅgeśa's treatment of absence is particularly subtle. Against those who deny absence the status of a separate ontological category, he argues that our perception of the absence of a pot on the floor cannot be explained by the characteristics of the floor alone: there must be something there—"absence" as a distinct qualifier—that functions in our failure to perceive the pot, which is the counterpositive. There are two principal kinds of absence: relational absence (prior, posterior, and eternal) and mutual absence, or difference based on identity (itaretarābhāva). Each has its own perceptual mechanism and epistemological consequences.

Influence and Legacy

The Navya-Nyāya School

The Tattvacintāmaṇi did not immediately displace all earlier Nyāya literature. Within a century of its composition, however, it was being studied and commented upon in India's principal centres of learning. The Navadvīpa (Bengal) tradition produced commentators of extraordinary refinement—Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Jagadīśa, and Gadādhara—who developed Gaṅgeśa's analytic vocabulary, particularly its theory of qualification (viśeṣaṇatā) and the logic of absence, into a terrain of abstract symbolism unprecedented in any philosophical tradition before the twentieth century. Its influence extended into Mīmāṃsā, Vedānta, grammar, Dharmaśāstra, and medicine, as scholars of different disciplines adopted Navya-Nyāya's technical vocabulary to articulate their positions with greater precision.

Mithila and the Living Tradition

In Mithila itself—and this is of particular importance to Videha magazine—the Tattvacintāmaṇi remained the summit of a paṇḍit's education. The Darbhanga Raj maintained a tradition of scholarly patronage that preserved the study of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila, even as Navadvīpa became its more celebrated centre. The pañjī system, the genealogical record of Maithil Brahmin families—of which Preeti Thakur has collected, scanned, and catalogued more than eleven thousand palm-leaf records for the Videha archive—is directly connected with the social structures that generated and perpetuated the paṇḍit tradition within which Gaṅgeśa worked. The Videha archive's preservation of Maithili and Sanskrit manuscripts, including writings by Ṭhakkuras and Miśras who were direct intellectual descendants of Gaṅgeśa's circle, establishes a living scholarly connection across seven centuries.

Modern Scholarship

Western scholarship on the Tattvacintāmaṇi began in earnest with Satish Chandra Vidyabhusana's History of Indian Logic (1921) and the Bibliotheca Indica edition edited by Kāmākhyānātha Tarkavāgīśa with Mathurānātha's Māthurī commentary (1884–1901). The twentieth century saw partial translations of individual sections: C. Goekoop's study of the vyāpti chapter (1967), B. K. Matilal's work on absence and indeterminate perception, Śibajīban Bhaṭṭācārya's extensive analyses of several divisions, and others. The first complete English translation of the Tattvacintāmaṇi appeared in three volumes by Stephen H. Phillips in 2020 (Bloomsbury), making the entire work accessible for the first time to readers without Sanskrit.

Name, Birthplace, Family, and Chronology

Gaṅgeśa or Gaṅgeśvara?

The Sahitya Akademi monograph maintains conclusively that Gaṅgeśvara was the formal name and Gaṅgeśa the familiar name—both referring to the same person. His son Vardhamāna pays homage in the Kiraṇāvalī-prakāśa with the words "gaṅgeśvarāya gurave pitre"; Gaṅgeśa himself writes in the benedictory verse of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, "gaṅgeśa-stute mitena vacase śrī-tattva-cintāmaṇim." The pañjī records describe him as "tattva-cintāmaṇi-kāraka mahāmahopādhyāya paramaguruḥ gaṅgeśvaraḥ."

The Potter Encyclopaedia confirms: "Gaṅgeśa was a native of Mithila. It appears that he was born and brought up in a village called Chādana, now unidentifiable, but lived later in life at Karion, the village of Udayana, about twelve miles south-east of Darbhanga. He belonged to the Kāśyapa gotra. Tradition has it that he had several wives, three sons and a daughter. One of the sons was Vardhamāna. Contradictory traditions say that Gaṅgeśa was either (a) a great prodigy or (b) an illiterate child."

Recovering Parallel History: Suppressed Pañjī Evidence

The parallel history of Maithili literature, as documented by the Videha movement and Gajendra Thakur, discloses a dimension of Gaṅgeśa's biography which, it alleges, institutional historians deliberately suppressed. The pañjī system, established under Harisiṃhadeva in the fourteenth century, is the genealogical recording system of Maithil Brahmins. When the Videha movement digitised and released the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī records in 2009, it brought to light what parallel history calls the "honour-killing of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's legacy."

The original pañjī records, according to this account, reveal that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya married a carmakāriṇī—a woman of a leather-working community—and that he was born five years after his father's death. These facts, which complicate his portrayal as a figure of unquestioned Brahmin orthodoxy, were, the author alleges, suppressed by Rāmānātha Jhā (the first convenor for Maithili at the Sahitya Akademi) when he transmitted biographical information to the historian Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya. The 2016 Sahitya Akademi monograph on Gaṅgeśa, parallel history observes, perpetuated this suppression. Parallel history accordingly presents Gaṅgeśa not simply as a monument of Brahmin scholarship but as a person who, like the dialectical method of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, challenges every presumption applied to him.

The implications of this biographical recovery are profound. The pañjī system was itself an instrument of caste regulation; yet its own records, once released, undermine the narrative of caste purity it was designed to sustain. Gaṅgeśa, the philosopher who insisted that every definition be tested against all possible counterexamples, becomes in parallel history a man whose life is itself a counterexample to the caste ideology that later laid claim to him. As Scharfstein observed of Navya-Nyāya method, "He and his followers construct definitions which stretch the mind and invite exact criticism." The critical spirit that animated his logic also animated his social existence—if the pañjī evidence is accepted.

Chronology

The authoritative assessment in Potter's Encyclopaedia assigns Gaṅgeśa a floruit of 1320 CE. The principal manuscript evidence includes a surviving copy of Vardhamāna's Kusumāñjali-prakāśa said, on epigraphic evidence, to date from 1300–1360; Gaṅgeśa quotes Śrīharṣa's Khaṇḍanakhaṇḍakhādya, and Śrīharṣa certainly predates 1233. Pañjī records compiled in Śaka 1310 (1388 CE) identify him by the epithet "tattvacintāmaṇikāraka"—the maker of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. The Sahitya Akademi monograph offers the range 1270–1370 CE; Scharfstein uses the floruit of 1320 CE. Parallel history, citing the pañjī account of his birth five years after his father's death, notes that this biographical detail places his active life firmly in the Karṇāṭa-dynasty period of Harisiṃhadeva (approximately 1295–1326 CE).

Mithila, the Karṇāṭa Dynasty, and the Intellectual Setting

The Karṇāṭa dynasty under Harisiṃhadeva (approximately 1295–1326 CE) provided the political framework of Gaṅgeśa's life. Harisiṃhadeva was a generous patron of Sanskrit learning. He ordered the pañjī genealogical records in 1310 CE; his minister Caṇḍeśvara Ṭhākura wrote prolifically; and he maintained a court in which the greatest Sanskrit scholars of the age competed and collaborated. Parallel history situates this within Mithila's long history as a centre of Nyāya–Mīmāṃsā scholarship—an intellectual capital which, as D. C. Bhattacharya documented, produced twenty-four Maithil logicians preceding Gaṅgeśa over seven centuries.

Yet parallel history also insists that this courtly culture rested upon an exclusionary social foundation. The same pañjī system that documented Gaṅgeśa's intellectual distinction enforced caste endogamy and marked the genealogical "disqualification" of those who transgressed its norms. The recovery of Gaṅgeśa's alleged inter-caste marriage from the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī is thus doubly significant: it reveals the pañjī as an instrument capable both of suppressing and, inadvertently, of preserving subversive facts about the very people it claims to celebrate.

Tattvacintāmaṇi — Structure, Innovation, and the Navya-Nyāya System

The Tattvacintāmaṇi and the Nature of Navya-Nyāya

Structure and Scope

V. P. Bhatta's introduction offers a clear account of the place of the Tattvacintāmaṇi in Indian intellectual history: "The Tattva Cintāmaṇi (T. C.) was composed by Gaṅgeśopādhyāya of Mithila in the thirteenth century CE. It inaugurated a new epoch in the development of Indian theories of knowledge and logic and is regarded as the first of the various works on Navya-Nyāya. It is divided into four books—Perception, Inference, Comparison, and Verbal Testimony—and treats the sixteen categories of Nyāya under these four headings." The Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa alone, as Bhatta's translation shows, contains thirteen major discussions or subsections: Maṅgalavāda, Prāmāṇyavāda, Pramālakṣaṇa, Apramāvāda, Pratyakṣavāda, Samavāyavāda/Sannikarṣavāda, Anupalabdhivāda, Abhāvavāda, Pratyakṣakāraṇavāda, Mano'ṇutvavāda, Pratyabhijñāvāda/Anuvyavasāyavāda, Nirvikalpakavāda, and Savikalpakavāda. The thirteenth-century dating is cited here as the position of Bhatta's introduction; the integrated chronology adopted in the present work places Gaṅgeśa's floruit around 1320 CE, correlating it with Harisiṃhadeva's reign and a parallel reading of the pañjī evidence.

The Potter–Bhattacharyya Encyclopaedia characterises the innovation: "Navya-Nyāya is really a logic of cognitions." By restricting its inquiry to the pramāṇas, the valid sources of knowledge, and abandoning the all-category framework of earlier Nyāya treatises, the Tattvacintāmaṇi achieved an unprecedented degree of analytical precision. The Sanskrit word jñāna, translated as "awareness," denotes not merely propositional acts but any state of conscious apprehension. A jñāna is always an occurrent event—something taking place at a particular time—never a dispositional belief. The corresponding term for a disposition is saṃskāra, an unconscious memory trace which, when activated, produces conscious recollection.

Method: Why Study This Work?

Bhatta emphasises its educational necessity: "It is therefore necessary that students and scholars of philosophy become familiar with the logic of the Navya-Nyāya method in order to understand the intricacies of philosophical theories … Thus the study of the T. C. is essential not only for its subject matter but also for its method." This insistence on method is itself philosophically significant. The Tattvacintāmaṇi does not merely reach conclusions; it demonstrates a way of reaching them that became a standard of intellectual rigour in Sanskrit philosophy for the following five centuries.

Scharfstein, in his comparative assessment, identifies the central methodological feature: "Gaṅgeśa makes philosophy the unquestioned domain of those skilled in a specialised language. He and his followers

construct definitions that stretch the mind and invite precise criticism, but only from those who have mastered the relevant technical terms and procedures of argument." Yet, as parallel history reminds us, this methodological exclusivity also became an instrument of caste exclusion: a language accessible principally to those possessing the social capital required to devote years to paṇḍit training.

Epistemology — Knowledge, Validity, and Error

The Nature of Knowledge (Jñāna): A Comprehensive Comparative Account

Knowledge Across the Schools: Bhatta's Introduction

The general introduction to V. P. Bhatta's translation of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa provides one of the most systematic comparative surveys of Indian theories of knowledge available in a single English-language source. It begins with the most fundamental question: what is knowledge?

Jñāna (knowledge), Bhatta explains, means buddhi (cognition) in the Nyāya-sūtra (1.1.15) and the Vaiśeṣika-sūtra (8.2); valid knowledge is a particular kind of cognition (buddhi-viśeṣa). In Nyāya, knowledge consists in awareness or apprehension and involves the disclosure of an object (artha-prakāśa). Naiyāyikas reject competing accounts. Against Buddhists and Mīmāṃsakas who regard knowledge as an activity (kriyā), Nyāya argues that the theory of activity "arises from confusing knowledge with the act of knowing." Against the Sāṃkhya and Yoga systems, which treat knowledge as a transformation (pariṇāma) of the intellect (buddhi), Nyāya objects that only the self—not an unconscious principle of intellect—can serve as the substratum of knowledge. Knowledge is a quality (guṇa) of the self, neither an activity nor a transformation of the intellect.

Classification of knowledge: Naiyāyikas divide cognition principally into two kinds—experience (anubhava) and memory (smṛti). Experience directly discloses objects; memory reproduces previous knowledge without presenting its objects directly. Both experience and memory may be valid (pramā) or invalid (apramā), depending on their causes.

Valid Cognition (Pramā): The Foundational Definition

Bhatta supplies the Nyāya definition with its full comparative apparatus: valid cognition (pramā) means "knowledge of a thing as it is" (yathārtha-jñāna). It is a true experience of an object (yathārthānubhava), an apprehension of reality. It is also definite and assured cognition (asaṃdigdha); hence it excludes the forms of invalid cognition—doubt, error, and hypothetical reasoning—as well as memory.

Valid cognition is true or unerring knowledge: it does not deviate from its object (arthāvyabhicārin). The familiar example, "This is a pot" (ayaṃ ghaṭaḥ), is valid cognition because it apprehends a pot as characterised by pothood. Thus valid cognition can be defined, as in the Nyāyakośa, as the

cognition of an object in which a quality actually present in it is apprehended as its distinguishing feature. Three factors are involved: the pramātṛ (knowing subject), prameya (object of knowledge), and pramāṇa (means of knowledge). A pramāṇa is the special or extraordinary causal condition (asādhāraṇa-kāraṇa) producing knowledge—an operative cause instrumental in acquiring valid cognition, and thus a method of knowing.

The Great Debate Between the Schools: Intrinsic versus Extrinsic Validity

The most philosophically rich part of Bhatta's introduction surveys the great interschool debate about the validity and invalidity of knowledge: whether they are constituted and known intrinsically (svataḥ) or extrinsically (parataḥ). This corresponds directly to Gaṅgeśa's own Prāmāṇyavāda section.

Sāṃkhya generally maintained that both validity and invalidity are constituted and known through intrinsic conditions—through the complete assemblage of causes producing cognition. Buddhists maintain that falsity or invalidity is intrinsic to cognition, whereas truth or validity is extrinsic. Mīmāṃsakas and Vedāntins hold that the validity of cognition is self-evident and constituted by intrinsic conditions, while its invalidity is established by other evidence and known through extrinsic conditions.

Naiyāyikas, however, generally hold that both are constituted and known by extrinsic conditions (parataḥ). Neither validity nor invalidity is self-evident; both must be inferred from circumstances external to the cognition. The Nyāya reply to the Sāṃkhya–Mīmāṃsā doctrine of intrinsic validity is decisive: "If validity were so constituted, there would be no invalid knowledge at all. Valid knowledge is something more than knowledge as such; hence the validity of knowledge, like its invalidity, requires special conditions and distinguishing features to constitute it. If validity were inherent in cognition, every cognition would possess truth and validity, and doubt and error would become untenable."

As Bhatta's survey of Western theories of truth observes, "There is no exact parallel in the West to the Indian theories of the validity and invalidity of knowledge." Reid considers truth simply the successful operation of knowledge; realists take it to be correspondence with facts; Alexander takes coherence as the basis of truth; pragmatists locate truth in the capacity to produce practically useful consequences. The Naiyāyika position—that neither validity nor invalidity is self-evident, and that both require inference from external conditions, such as successful or unsuccessful activity—is genuinely distinctive.

Invalid Cognition: Doubt, Error, and Hypothetical Reasoning

Bhatta gives a systematic account of three forms of invalid cognition addressed in Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi. Doubt (saṃśaya) is a conflicting apprehension (vimarśa) concerning a single object, consisting in cognitions that attribute incompatible properties to it. "Is this a post or a person?"—doubt oscillates between alternatives without reaching a determinate,

discriminating cognition. Doubt may arise from five causes: a common property; an exceptional property; mutually contradictory testimony concerning the self; irregularity in perception; and non-apprehension concerning the existence or nonexistence of something.

Error or illusion (viparyaya) is the second kind of invalid cognition —"apprehension of a thing otherwise than as it is" (ayathārtha). In error, an object is apprehended as possessing a quality that is not present in it. Naiyāyikas propose the theory of misapprehension as something other than it is (anyathākhyāti): whereas valid cognition is objective, invalid cognition becomes subjective through the superimposition of an extraneous feature upon the object. In an illusion, owing to a defect in the sense organ, one fails to determine the actual properties of the object (a shell) and imputes to it an alien property that is absent (silver). Error thus results in the judgement of one object (the shell) as something else (silver): anyathākhyāti.

The comparative analysis of theories of illusion is extensive. The Buddhist Yogācāra school proposes that error or illusion consists in the presentation of a subjective idea as an external or extramental reality (ātmakhyāti). The Mādhyamikas, who deny existence as ordinarily conceived, reject the theory of cognition of nonexistence. Vācaspati Miśra proposes that error is the apprehension of what is unreal (asatkhyāti). Prābhākara Mīmāṃsakas hold that error consists in non-apprehension or failure to distinguish (akhyāti). Advaitins propose that error or illusion is cognition of what is inexplicable (anirvacanīya). Naiyāyikas refute these positions, insisting that an error must be a distinct and determinate cognition capable of prompting action. It cannot simply be ignorance, for in it there is a cognition of an object as it is not.

Tarka (hypothetical or suppositional reasoning) is the third form of invalid cognition. It is a species of implicative reasoning by which the validity of an argument can be tested. In tarka the reasoning procedure (Tarka-bhāṣā, p. 43) involves drawing out an unacceptable consequence (aniṣṭa-prasaṅga), whose logical effect is to expose the untenability of premises supporting a contrary thesis. Five forms of tarka—ātmāśraya (self-dependence), anyonyāśraya (mutual dependence), cakraka (circularity), anavasthā (infinite regress), and pramāṇa-bādhitārtha-prasaṅga (a consequence contradicted by valid knowledge)—correspond directly to Gaṅgeśa's treatment of the function of tarka in the Anumāna-khaṇḍa.

Perception (Pratyakṣa) — The First Book of the Tattvacintāmaṇi

The Nature and Definition of Perception

The Nyāya Definition and Gaṅgeśa's Innovation

Bhatta's introduction to the nature of perception (pratyakṣa) begins with its foundational philosophical status: "Perception is the most fundamental and final test of knowledge. One may question the truth or validity of inference

and so on, but one cannot question the truth or validity of perception; it is beyond question." The Prācya-Naiyāyikas (Old Nyāya philosophers) define perception as knowledge produced by contact between a sense organ and its object (indriyārtha-sannikarṣa). This definition follows the etymological meaning of the term pratyakṣa (Nyāya-bhāṣya on 1.1.4): perception denotes the operation of the senses in reaching objects.

Gaṅgeśa and the Navya-Naiyāyikas, however (Tattvacintāmaṇi 1.3 …), define perception as immediate cognition (sākṣātkāri-jñāna), produced without a prior cognition serving as its instrumental cause (jñāna-kāraṇakaṃ jñānam). In their view, this definition applies to every instance of perception, since immediacy (sākṣātkāritva) and arising without a preceding cognition are common to all perceptions. Thus only the Navya-Nyāya definition—immediate cognition not generated through a previous cognition—covers all cases of perception; immediacy is an essential characteristic of every perception.

Bhatta compares this innovation with Western perspectives: "According to Western philosophy, the truth of perception is unquestionable and self-evident. Thus J. F. Mill (A System of Logic, p. 4) says that whatever we know by consciousness (intuition) is known beyond the possibility of question. And W. T. Marvin (The New Realism, p. 66) says that perception is the final decisive test, and as such does not presuppose its own possibility." The Buddhist definition—perception as an unerring apprehension of a given object free from all conceptual construction (kalpanāpoḍham)—is rejected on the ground that "if perception is determined by objects, then all true knowledge ought to be perception." Vedāntins define perception as immediate and timeless consciousness (caitanya), but this does not distinguish a mental modification (manovṛtti) from its object, since perceptual immediacy cannot be produced merely by the stimulation of a sense organ.

The Senses, Mind, Self, and Their Functions

Bhatta gives a detailed account of the mechanism of perception. Nyāya holds that perception arises from contact between a sense organ and an object, and that the self comes into contact with the object through the mind. Four operative causes enter into the production of perception: the senses, the object, the mind (manas), and the self (Nyāya-sūtra 1.1.4). Naiyāyikas and Vaiśeṣikas hold that the mind (manas) is an internal sense organ (antarindriya) belonging to the self (ātman). The perception of objects cannot arise solely from external senses meeting their objects: it occurs when the external senses also establish contact with the internal organ, manas. As the mind is atomic in size, different external senses make contact with it at different times and thereby give rise to perceptions of different objects.

The self (ātman) is the individual self (jīvātman), the substratum of all knowledge. Cognition and other mental qualities belong to the self alone, not to any other material substance, precisely because they are mental. Selves differ among embodied individuals and are eternal (nitya) and all-pervasive

(vibhu). Naiyāyikas (Bhāṣāpariccheda, 51) do not accept the Vedāntic view that the self is eternal, self-luminous consciousness (cit). Rather, it is a substance (dravya) that supports qualities such as cognition and is thus known as the locus of the awareness of "I" or ego.

There are six senses (indriyas): smell (ghrāṇa), taste (rasanā), sight (cakṣus), touch (tvak), hearing (śrotra), and the internal organ or mind (manas). Their function is to produce cognition of objects; the senses function through direct contact with objects. Six kinds of sense–object connection are recognised: (1) conjunction (saṃyoga); (2) inherence in what is conjoined (saṃyukta-samavāya); (3) inherence in what inheres in the conjoined (saṃyukta-samaveta-samavāya); (4) inherence (samavāya); (5) inherence in what is inherent (samaveta-samavāya); and (6) qualificative relation (viśeṣaṇatā).

Ordinary and Extraordinary Perception

Perception is of two kinds: ordinary (laukika) and extraordinary (alaukika). Ordinary perception arises through sense–object contact, whereas extraordinary perception arises through an exceptional mode of connection. Ordinary perception is further divided into external (bāhya) and internal or mental (mānasa) perception. External perception relates to contact through the external senses; internal perception (Bhāṣāpariccheda, 57) arises through the internal sense organ, manas, and its objects include experiences of pleasure, pain, desire, aversion, cognition, and effort.

The Nyāya system recognises three forms of extraordinary (alaukika) perception: (1) perception qualified by the character of a universal (sāmānya-lakṣaṇa); (2) perception qualified through a prior cognition (jñāna-lakṣaṇa); and (3) perception through yogic contact (yogaja). Perception through a universal is the first type of extraordinary perception: the cognition of an entire class of things as qualified by a common or universal property. For example, "This is a pot" (ayaṃ ghaṭaḥ) apprehends the pot as qualified by the universal pothood. Naiyāyikas consider this capacity indispensable; without admitting perception mediated by a universal, knowledge of an invariable relation such as "Wherever there is smoke, there is fire" would be undermined.

Perception qualified through prior knowledge (jñāna-lakṣaṇa) is the second form of extraordinary cognition. It apprehends an object that comes into sensory relation through the operation of a prior cognition (viṣayiyasya tasyaiva vyāpāraḥ). The example "I see fragrant sandalwood" (surabhi-candanam) illustrates this form of perception: fragrance cannot be grasped by the organ of sight, and must therefore be brought into the visual apprehension through the operation of knowledge. Naiyāyikas further maintain that illusions such as "This [shell] is a piece of silver" (idaṃ rajatam) likewise require the operation of earlier knowledge of silver, since the organ of sight is in contact with the shell, not with silver. Perception characterised by jñāna-lakṣaṇa (yogaja) constitutes the third type: an apprehension of objects past, present, and future through capacities generated in the mind by meditation (yogābhyāsa-janito dharma-viśeṣaḥ).

Indeterminate and Determinate Perception — Gaṅgeśa's Central Doctrine

Three Types of Ordinary Perception

According to Bhatta, ordinary perception has three forms: (1) indeterminate perception (nirvikalpaka), (2) determinate perception (savikalpaka), and (3) recognition or subsequent awareness (pratyabhijñā or anuvyavasāya). Nirvikalpaka perception or cognition is the first kind of ordinary perception. It is the most abstract apprehension of objects: a simple awareness of an object's existence without verbal predication. Savikalpaka perception is the most concrete apprehension of objects together with their qualities. Recognition is a subsequent cognition following determinate perception, clearly distinct from both indeterminate and determinate perception.

The Debate Between Schools on Indeterminate Perception

Vedāntins (Rāmānuja on Brahma-sūtra 1.1.1) hold that indeterminate knowledge is awareness of sheer being (sanmātra)—"This is something" (idaṃ kiñcit)—and does not include the specification of relations or attributes. Buddhists (Pramāṇasamuccaya, Chapter 1) maintain that indeterminate knowledge is the only form of valid knowledge: it is free of all ideas or conceptual constructions (kalpanāpoḍham). Mīmāṃsakas take it to be the perceptual apprehension of a real individual that unites universal and particular.

The Prābhākara Mīmāṃsaka position is important: indeterminate knowledge arises spontaneously when the senses meet their objects—it is the perception of a child and of comparable perceivers. The Prābhākara Mīmāṃsakas' refutation of the grammarians is also important: indeterminate cognition is one's first experience of an object, a simple apprehension of its existence without a verbal relation. In determinate cognition the object and its property stand in a subject–predicate relation; in indeterminate cognition, that object and property have not yet been connected in such a relation. Naiyāyikas, by contrast, maintain that indeterminate cognition is a real but supersensible state of awareness (atīndriya). Since it is an undifferentiated awareness of an as-yet-undetermined object, it cannot be a determinate perception.

Determinate Perception and the Structure of Qualification

Determinate perception or cognition (savikalpaka) is the second form of ordinary perception. It is the most concrete apprehension of an object along with its qualities. Vedāntins (Rāmānuja on Brahma-sūtra 1.1.1) hold that determinate cognition is a distinctive cognition that discriminates an object (vikalpa) from other objects. Later Advaitin epistemologists agree that savikalpaka cognition is a verbally articulated judgement about an object as an individual whole. Buddhists (Nyāyavārttika-tātparyaṭīkā on 1.1.4, as cited here) treat determinate cognition as a verbal expression in which an object is determined through concepts of name, class, and the like (nāma-jāty-ādi-yojanā-sahita).

Naiyāyikas (Bhāṣāpariccheda, 58) hold that determinate cognition is qualified knowledge (viśiṣṭa-jñāna), in which an object is known as qualified by attributes. Its object is thus apprehended through specified qualities. The judgement "This is a cow" (ayaṃ gauḥ), for instance, apprehends the animal as qualified by cowhood. Determinate cognition is accordingly a proposition in which the object or individual is the subject and the qualifying attribute is the predicate. Whereas indeterminate perception is the first stage of ordinary perception, determinate perception is its second stage.

Recognition (Pratyabhijñā, Anuvyavasāya)

Recognition (pratyabhijñā or anuvyavasāya) constitutes the third type of ordinary perception in this account. It is a subsequent cognition following determinate perception and is clearly distinct from both indeterminate and determinate cognition. In its broad sense, recognition means apprehending the nature of an object; in its narrower sense, it means knowing again something already known. Nyāya philosophy uses pratyabhijñā in this second, narrower sense.

Naiyāyikas (Mitabhāṣiṇī, p. 25) hold recognition to be cognition of an object now perceived as the same object perceived before. Thus the recognition "This [Devadatta] is that Devadatta" (so'yaṃ devadattaḥ) apprehends the presently perceived Devadatta as the Devadatta previously perceived. Such recognition arises both from the senses and from traces (saṃskāras) left by earlier experience of the object (Nyāyamañjarī, p. 459). Recognition therefore involves both perception and recollection, since it is produced through the senses as well as through those retained traces.

Comparative and Global-Philosophical Perspectives

Gaṅgeśa, Descartes, and Leibniz: Logic-Sensitive Metaphysics

Among the most illuminating contributions of Scharfstein's A Comparative History is the systematic comparison, in Chapter 10 ("Logic-Sensitive, Methodical Metaphysics: Gaṅgeśa, Descartes, Leibniz"), of Gaṅgeśa with Descartes (1596–1650) and Leibniz (1646–1716). The organising theme is the search for certainty through the methodical application of reasoning: each philosopher seeks to establish knowledge by vindicating procedures of argument rather than simply adding more empirical material.

Scharfstein identifies several structural similarities. All three philosophers are committed logicians who seek to improve methods of reasoning and apply them to the full range of human thought—not just philosophy but life itself, extending in Descartes's case even to medicine and in Leibniz's to law. Gaṅgeśa's concern with valid induction and economical explanation is, in spirit, close to that of contemporary philosophers of science. All three also "seek a metaphysically unquestionable foundation for understanding the world," bringing together the empirical and theoretical, secular and sacred. All respond to powerful sceptical challenges: Gaṅgeśa to the Cārvākas and

Śrīharṣa, Descartes to the Cartesian evil demon, and Leibniz to radical empiricism.

The differences are equally instructive. Descartes breaks with tradition and refuses to cite his sources; Gaṅgeśa, like other Indian philosophers, engages respectfully with his predecessor Udayana even when departing from him. Descartes's method is axiomatic-deductive, seeking certainty through clear and distinct ideas. Gaṅgeśa's is definitional-dialectical, seeking certainty through the comprehensive testing and rejection of rival definitions of vyāpti and other crucial concepts. Leibniz, a genuinely creative logician, invents new formalism. Gaṅgeśa works wholly within an inherited vocabulary but transforms it through the precision and completeness of his analysis of definitions.

Scharfstein's own comparative judgement is that "Gaṅgeśa makes philosophy the unquestioned domain of those skilled in a specialised language. He and his followers construct definitions that stretch the mind and invite precise criticism, but only from those who have mastered the relevant technical terms and procedures of argument." The Navya-Nyāya system inaugurated by Gaṅgeśa effectively created a formal language for philosophical discourse, one which in surprising respects anticipated the development of symbolic logic in late nineteenth-century Europe—though without symbolic notation.

Gaṅgeśa and Udayana: Innovation Within Tradition

The relationship between Gaṅgeśa and his most important predecessor, Udayana (fl. 1050 CE), is a central concern in both Scharfstein and the Potter Encyclopaedia. Scharfstein remarks: "Because so much of his philosophy is an elaboration of Udayana's, to whom we now turn, Gaṅgeśa's originality shows itself more in his dialectic, in the care and sharpness with which he argues—splitting hairs, it is easy to say—than in original doctrine." A footnote adds: "Udayana may be the more original of the two. Greater originality has also been ascribed to Gaṅgeśa's successor, commentator, and critic, Raghunātha (fl. 1500 CE)." The Potter Encyclopaedia identifies Scharfstein's comparative chapter on Udayana (Chapter 9 of his book) as providing the philosophical context in which the chapter on Gaṅgeśa should be read.

The Potter Encyclopaedia, however, offers a more nuanced assessment of Gaṅgeśa's originality. Its major innovations include: (1) the decisive treatment of vyāpti after a comprehensive examination of previous attempts; (2) the development of the theory of inhibitors and what they inhibit (pratibandhaka–pratibadhya) into a systematic logic of cognition; (3) a shift from Buddhists to Mīmāṃsakas as the primary adversaries, reflecting the changing philosophical landscape of fourteenth-century India; (4) the "linguistic turn" of the Śabda-khaṇḍa, giving Navya-Nyāya its own philosophy of language; and (5) above all, the creation of a new intellectual community through the Tattvacintāmaṇi itself, which became the common point of reference for all subsequent Naiyāyika debate.

The Metaphysical Framework and Raghunātha Śiromaṇi

Navya-Nyāya Metaphysics: Categories and Their Fate

The introduction to the Potter Encyclopaedia (Chapter 3, "Metaphysics") traces the development of the seven Vaiśeṣika categories from Gaṅgeśa to Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, showing how the analytical rigour of Navya-Nyāya gradually undermined the very metaphysical structure it had inherited. Gaṅgeśa himself is metaphysically conservative, working within the framework of seven categories: substance (dravya), quality (guṇa), motion or action (karma), universal (sāmānya), particularity (viśeṣa), inherence (samavāya), and absence (abhāva). He defends inherence as "a separate category, irreducible, perceptible, and one." He argues against the view that absence can be eliminated in favour of a mere difference relation.

The treatment of absence is a particularly striking field of development. Gaṅgeśa devotes a chapter of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa to absence but does not raise the problem of the absence of an absence. Later commentators, especially Raghunātha—who adopts as a working principle that "the absolute absence of the absolute absence of a thing is the thing itself"—employ absences with growing technical sophistication as instruments of quantification. As the Encyclopaedia notes, "One of the most fascinating features of the development of Navya-Nyāya from Gaṅgeśa to Raghunātha is the remarkable increase in the use of absences as devices of quantification."

Raghunātha Śiromaṇi: Gaṅgeśa's Great Critic and Successor

The Potter Encyclopaedia casts Raghunātha Śiromaṇi (fl. 1500 CE) as the thinker who closes the period surveyed in Volume 6 and sets the agenda for all subsequent Navya-Nyāya. The famous story of Raghunātha's encounter with Pakṣadhara Miśra (Jayadeva) in Mithila—preserved in Jha "Ashok"'s monograph—marks the point at which the Navadvīpa (Bengal) tradition became the principal vehicle for Navya-Nyāya's further development. Raghunātha's Dīdhiti, a commentary on the Tattvacintāmaṇi, is the tradition's most important secondary work, generating its own vast commentary literature through Jagadīśa, Gadādhara, and later scholars.

Raghunātha's relationship to Gaṅgeśa is one of critical expansion: he accepts Gaṅgeśa's framework while subjecting almost every particular doctrine to radical revision. In the words of the Encyclopaedia, "Raghunātha rejects Gaṅgeśa's reasoning (on several technical points)"—and the pattern indeed recurs throughout the volume. Concerning universals, where Gaṅgeśa is conservative, Raghunātha eliminates almost all genuine universals, treating common properties as imposed or adventitious conditions (upādhi). Concerning particularity (viśeṣa), he abolishes the category altogether. Concerning inherence, where Gaṅgeśa defends a single inherence, Raghunātha declares that there are as many instances of inherence as there are pairs of things related in that way. It is Raghunātha who makes the delimitor relation (avacchedakatva) a particularly important analytical device. The Potter Encyclopaedia concludes: "How much of Raghunātha's equipment was

his invention, and how much he received from his teachers and tradition, cannot be said until closer study has been made of those who intervened between the two great Naiyāyikas."

Legacy, the Commentary Tradition, and Mithila's Living Heritage

The Commentary Tradition

The commentarial tradition surrounding the Tattvacintāmaṇi is among the most extensive in Sanskrit literature. Jha "Ashok"'s monograph provides a table of twenty-three known commentators and their works; the Potter Encyclopaedia surveys the tradition in fifty numbered entries, from Gaṅgeśa and Vaṭeśvara to Raghunātha Śiromaṇi. Geographically, it falls into three strands: Maithila, Bengal (Navadvīpa), and the South.

In Mithila, the tradition runs from Vardhamāna Upādhyāya's direct connection to the text through Pakṣadhara Miśra's (Jayadeva's) Āloka commentary and the later internal dispute between the Āloka lineage (the Pakṣadhara–Yajñapati line) and the Dūṣaṇoddhāra lineage (the Narahari–Mādhava line). In Bengal, Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's Dīdhiti became the principal object of study, attracting commentaries by Rucidatta Miśra, Jagadīśa Tarkālaṃkāra, Gadādhara Bhaṭṭācārya, Mathurānātha Tarkavāgīśa, and many others. Scharfstein quotes Matilal on the achievement of the tradition: "The master of Navya-Nyāya did not first fashion conclusions and afterwards justify them by theory. He was seriously engaged in following reality wherever it might lead him, imposing his own prejudices as lightly as possible … This is precisely the quality that I find admirable in creative workers in modern science and philosophy."

The introduction to the Potter Encyclopaedia explains the scholarly challenge posed by this tradition: "Two of India's most remarkable philosophers, Gaṅgeśa and Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, are included in these pages—in fact, they begin and end the surveyed period … only two hundred years, roughly 1310 to 1510. There is good reason for concentrating so intensely on this short interval." The implication is that few comparable intervals elsewhere in world philosophy have produced two figures of similar stature within one tradition, while the intervening two centuries yielded dozens of commentators whose works constituted a continuous, self-critical and philosophically rigorous conversation of the highest order.

Gaṅgeśa in the Parallel History of Maithili Culture

Mainstream versus Parallel Historiography

The parallel history of Maithili literature—as documented in the research of the Videha movement and in A Parallel History of Maithili Literature—presents a comprehensive counter-narrative to the institutional Maithili literary canon. Mainstream history, crystallised in Jayakant Mishra's two-volume History of Maithili Literature (1949–1950) and institutionally implemented by the Sahitya Akademi from 1965, was "fundamentally an exercise in identity formation, designed to establish Maithili as an independent language rather than a dialect of Hindi." Although this undertaking helped secure Maithili's eventual recognition in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, parallel historiography argues that it also established a conservative, Brahmin-centred norm that excluded liberal and marginalised voices.

The parallel history unfolds across nine layers: (1) the Buddhist foundations—the fifty Caryāpada songs of twenty-three Siddha poets, including Luipāda, Kānhapāda and Saraha, as the true roots of Maithili song; (2) the two Vidyāpatis—one of Videha's most significant scholarly interventions, separating the celebrated Padāvalī poet, placed before Jyotirishwar, from Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura (1350–1435), the Sanskrit/Avahaṭṭha author; (3) the suppressed Gaṅgeśa—original pañjī manuscripts preserving the claim that the philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya was born five years after his father's death and married a woman from the leather-working community; (4) colonial-era protest poetry—Faturilal's famine poem of 1873–74; (5) the exclusion of Harimohan Jha; (6) living masters—Rajdev Mandal and Bechan Thakur; (7) disclosures under the Right to Information Act by Vineet Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–12), alleging that more than ninety per cent of Sahitya Akademi appointments went to friends or relatives of advisory-board members; (8) the Nepal dimension—recognising the Maithili of Nepal's Tarai as equally central; and (9) the digital counter-archive—Videha itself.

The Suppressed Gaṅgeśa: The "Honour Killing" of a Legacy

Parallel historiography calls the institutional treatment of Gaṅgeśa's biography an "honour killing." Its specific allegation, documented in the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī (a "black book" of genealogical records released through Gajendra Thakur's Videha in 2009), is that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya married a carmakāriṇī, a woman of the leather-working community, and was born five years after his father's death. It further alleges that Ramanath Jha—the first Maithili convenor at the Sahitya Akademi and a principal gatekeeper of the institutional Maithili canon—suppressed this information in his exchanges with the historian Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya. According to this account, the Sahitya Akademi's 2016 Makers of Indian Literature monograph on Gaṅgeśa, authored by Udaynath Jha "Ashok," perpetuated that suppression.

The significance of this recovery extends beyond biography. The pañjī system, celebrated in institutional history as an emblem of cultural distinctiveness, was designed to preserve caste purity by recording genealogical information that could be used to sanction or reject marriage alliances. By releasing the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī records, the Videha movement argued that the system itself, when honestly examined, undermines the ideology of purity it was intended to sustain. One of Mithila's greatest philosophers—a thinker who insisted that every definition be tested against every possible counterexample—lived a life which, on this reading, was itself a counterexample to the caste norms of those who later claimed him.

Gaṅgeśa in Maithili's Wider Intellectual Ecology

The parallel history situates Gaṅgeśa within an intellectual ecology more plural than the institutional narrative allows. The same fourteenth-century Mithila that produced the Tattvacintāmaṇi also knew the influence of the Siddhācārya tradition on Nāth-sect literature; Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varṇaratnākara, described here as the earliest prose work in any northeastern Indian language, with its Arabic and Persian loanwords; and networks of intercaste cultural exchange in which, on this account, Gaṅgeśa's family participated. The parallel history observes that "Mithila was not afflicted by conflict of this kind, which is why logic or Nyāya flourished to such a degree there that no other region of India produced as many Nyāya scholars or texts." It adds, however, that this intellectual excellence was achieved and sustained in a social world more complex than institutional history has been willing to acknowledge.

Scripts, Language, and Digital Recovery

The parallel history documents the history of Mithila's scripts as central to cultural identity. The Tirhuta script (Mithilākṣara), developed from an eastern variety of the Gupta script, was used for scholarly, cultural and religious purposes for almost a millennium. The twentieth-century shift to Devanagari —driven by printing convenience and administrative reasoning in the Hindi-speaking belt—is regarded by parallel historians as a form of cultural dispossession. The Videha movement's successful standardisation of Tirhuta in Unicode (2014) and its development of digital fonts represent a technical reclamation of linguistic sovereignty.

The digital archive that Videha has built around Mithila's intellectual heritage—thousands of digitised books, 11,000 transcribed Tirhuta palm-leaf manuscripts, Dūṣaṇa Pañjī records, the first Maithili website aggregator, Tirhuta Unicode representation, and Maithili localisation for Google Translate and Wikipedia—constitutes what the parallel history calls a "living parallel institution." In this archive, Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi belongs not as a monument to Brahmin orthodoxy but as part of an entire civilisational inheritance whose complexity, the argument maintains, has repeatedly been diminished in the institutional account.

The Revival of the Maithili Ghazal: Anchinhar Akhar

The parallel history documents one of the parallel Maithili literary movement's most striking recent achievements: the revival of the Maithili ghazal through the Anchinhar Akhar group. The movement began on 11 April 2008 with the launch of the Anchinhar Akhar blog, initiated by Ashish Anchinhar and subsequently co-edited by Gajendra Thakur. Within a decade, it brought between 350 and 400 new or previously marginalised writers into Maithili literary circulation, bypassing institutional gatekeepers altogether.

The ghazal—an Arabic-Persian poetic form defined by its couplets (sher/bait), strict metrical patterns (bahr), rhyme (qāfiya), refrain (radīf), and the poet's signature in the final couplet (maqṭa, including takhallus)—had long met resistance from the institutional Maithili literary establishment because of its association with Urdu and Muslim cultural traditions. The parallel history points to an irony: Jyotirishwar's Varṇaratnākara uses Arabic and Persian loanwords, while the speech of Muslim weavers (jolāhī bolī) is itself a creolised form of Maithili. "The formal revival of the Maithili ghazal in the twenty-first century is therefore less a rupture than the recovery of a suppressed intercultural thread."

Gajendra Thakur, recognised in this account as Maithili's first arūzī, or scholar of ghazal prosody, composed the first Ghazalśāstram (a treatise on Maithili ghazal metrics). It offered contemporary poets a systematic theoretical framework and demonstrated that the qāfiya–radīf structure could be successfully adapted to Maithili's moraic metrical tradition inherited from Prakrit and Apabhraṃśa. The exacting method Gaṅgeśa applied to definitions of vyāpti—testing each proposed definition against counterexamples until the most precise formulation was reached—is here applied by the movement to ghazal prosody, establishing formal rules that make the Maithili ghazal a coherent genre rather than a loose adaptation.

Conclusion

Part III · Technical Navya-Nyāya, Kārakavāda, and Modern Readings

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya: Philosophy, History, and Resistance

This research study traces Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya through six major sources which, taken together, illuminate six distinct aspects of his significance. From the Sahitya Akademi monograph and D. C. Bhattacharya's History come the biographical particulars: his name, birthplace, gotra, family, chronology and the twenty-four predecessors whose work he synthesised and surpassed. From the Potter–Bhattacharya Encyclopaedia comes the technical architecture of Navya-Nyāya: its relational vocabulary, logic of cognition, theories of truth and awareness, and the trajectory from Gaṅgeśa to Raghunātha Śiromaṇi. From Scharfstein's comparative history comes his position in world philosophy alongside Descartes and Leibniz, and the meaning of his

methodological rigour in a cross-cultural framework. From V. P. Bhatta's translation of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa comes the first book of the Tattvacintāmaṇi in English: the full theory of cognition, from its comparative foundations through valid and invalid knowledge, perception and its types, indeterminate and determinate awareness, recognition and extraordinary perception, with inter-school debates systematically mapped across Sāṃkhya, Buddhist, Mīmāṃsā, Vedānta and Jain positions. From the parallel history comes the biographical information alleged to have been suppressed in the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī, the institutional "honour killing" of Gaṅgeśa's legacy, and his recovery as a figure belonging to the whole of Mithila rather than only to its elite minority.

The three hundred pages of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, which generated a million pages of commentary, were produced by a person whose life, this account argues, did not conform to the later caste orthodoxy that claimed him. The greatest logician of the Sanskrit tradition, a philosopher who demanded that every definition be tested against every possible counterexample, lived a counterexample. This is perhaps the parallel history's most profound lesson about Gaṅgeśa: his philosophical method and biographical reality are not contradictory but convergent. Both embody the principle that reality is more complex than any single framework and that honest inquiry requires a willingness to revise every assumption, however deeply held.

V. P. Bhatta's preface closes with a statement of the Tattvacintāmaṇi's continuing relevance: "The importance of the work (T. C.) in the context of philosophy, logic and epistemology cannot be overemphasised." The Potter Encyclopaedia judges that "Gaṅgeśa possessed an extraordinary genius that safely places him among the world's greatest philosophical minds." The parallel history points to pañjī evidence said to show that he was born five years after his father's death and married a woman of the leather-working community; the presentation of these biographical claims has become a subject of controversy in institutional historiography. For Scharfstein, his engagement with valid induction is "like that of contemporary philosophers of science in spirit." Videha's conclusion is that he belongs to the whole of Mithila, not to its gatekeepers.

All six perspectives are necessary. None alone suffices. The man who wrote in the opening verses of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, "Gaṅgeśa-stute mitena vacase"—"I, Gaṅgeśa, say this briefly"—demands to be read on his own terms. Seven centuries of commentary, institutional appropriation, parallel-historical recovery and digital archiving have still not exhausted those terms.

The Tattvacintāmaṇi's "astonishingly forbidding style and thought" have long discouraged translators. Yet that very analytical severity—the hair-splitting distinctions, the exhaustive enumeration and rejection of competing definitions, the demand that every term carry exactly the weight placed upon it—is precisely what makes Gaṅgeśa not merely a historical curiosity but an enduring contributor to philosophy: a demonstration that clarity of thought,

wherever achieved, is a human accomplishment transcending the boundaries of tradition, language and time.

Gaṅgeśa refined a logic-sensitive metaphysics inherited from a long line of predecessors who had developed the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika synthesis and answered Buddhist arguments:

• Udayanācārya: the "real founder," whose Lakṣaṇamālā offered the first definition of valid knowledge (pramā) that came under attack from sceptics.

• Maṇikaṇṭha Miśra: author of the Nyāyaratna, whose work on inference and pervasion (vyāpti) was a primary source for Gaṅgeśa, who often cited him without naming him.

• Taraṇi Miśra: author of the Ratnakoṣa, whose positions on negation and causation were cited—and frequently refuted—by Gaṅgeśa.

• Śaśadhara: author of the Nyāyasiddhāntadīpa, whose intricate style, applied to topics such as "glittering gold," provided a template for Gaṅgeśa's complexity.

• Soṇadopādhyāya: a scholar who pioneered a theory of negation in which the counterpositive is delimited by a property residing in a different locus (vyadhikaraṇa-dharmāvacchinna-pratiyogitā).

Gaṅgeśa's family life included his wife Vallabhā; three sons—Vardhamāna, Sūpana and Hariśarmā—and a daughter.

• Vardhamāna Upādhyāya: Gaṅgeśa's eldest son and pupil, he became a distinguished scholar and wrote the Prakāśa and Upāya commentaries, bridging the old and new traditions of logic.

• His daughter: she married Sāṭhe Upādhyāya of Babhaniyam village; their son Ratnākara is entered in genealogical records as Gaṅgeśa's grandson.

The parallel-history movement, drawing on the Videha archives, has recovered disputed particulars about Gaṅgeśa's lineage that it alleges were suppressed by institutional historians such as Ramanath Jha. The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī (the "Black Book"), released digitally in 2009, contains a "secret" record according to which Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death (pitṛ parokṣe pañca varṣa vyatīte). The record further identifies his wife Vallabhā as a carmakāriṇī, belonging to a leather-working community. Parallel-history researchers argue that these facts were suppressed to preserve elite social hierarchies, characterising the suppression as an "honour killing" of his authentic legacy.

Technical Method: The Logic of Cognition

Navya-Nyāya is essentially a "pramāṇa-Nyāya," a logic of sources of knowledge, in contrast with the category-centred "padārtha-Nyāya" of the older school. It employs "relational abstracts" to specify particular aspects of cognitive states:

• Knowledge (jñāna): defined as a contextual cognitive act operating through a relation of inhibition (pratibandhakatā), whereby one cognition can obstruct another.

• The qualifier–qualificand framework: propositional awareness is structured by representing a qualificand () as qualified by a qualifier () through a relation ().

• Limitor (avacchedaka): a "mode of presentation" specifying precisely which property makes a relation possible. In the case of a blue pot, for example, pothood is the delimitor of the property of being the qualificand residing in the pot.

• Quantification: Navya-Nyāya achieves some of the results of Western quantification through abstraction, as in the proposition: "There is a general absence of fire delimited by the locus of the absence of fire in smoke."

Structural Overview of the Tattvacintāmaṇi

The Tattvacintāmaṇi is organised around the four pramāṇas and divided into forty-six major sections (prakaraṇas), comprising approximately 12,000 granthas.

Book One: Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa

Divided into twenty-five subsections, this book establishes perception as a primary source of knowledge.

• Maṅgalavāda: Gaṅgeśa debates whether an auspicious invocation removes obstacles or produces completion, and concludes, through the logic of positive and negative concomitance (anvaya–vyatireka), that it removes obstacles.

• Prāmāṇyavāda: this defends a "hyper-reliabilist" or "non-defeasibilist" position in which the actual source of knowledge is factive. Gaṅgeśa rejects the Mīmāṃsā doctrine of svataḥ-prāmāṇya (intrinsic self-validation), maintaining that knowledge is validated externally by the success of subsequent activity.

• Anuvyavasāya: an inner perception by the mind of its own states. Gaṅgeśa regards this as infallible.

• Stages of perception: nirvikalpaka (indeterminate awareness of qualifications) is distinguished from savikalpaka (determinate, conceptually articulated perception).

• Ontological debates: Volume Two of Bhatta's translation includes debates over whether air is perceived by touch and the theory that gold is a kind of fiery light rather than an earthly substance.

• The internal organ (manas): Gaṅgeśa holds that the mind is of atomic size (aṇu), accounting for why multiple perceptions cannot occur simultaneously.

Book Two: Anumāna-khaṇḍa

The most intricate portion of the work, dealing with natural invariable concomitance, or vyāpti.

• Siṃha-vyāghrī definitions: it includes the celebrated "lion-and-tigress" definitions of vyāpti.

• Pakṣatā: the condition of being the subject of an inference, defined in relation to a property-bearer for which there is a desire to establish the probandum (sādhya).

• Īśvarānumāna: the inference of God as maker of the universe on the premise that the universe is an effect.

Book Three: Upamāna-khaṇḍa

The shortest division, analysing knowledge of similarity between a known and an unknown object, such as a cow and a gavaya (wild ox).

Book Four: Śabda-khaṇḍa

This constitutes one-third of the trilogy, as the source describes it, and focuses on verbal cognition (śābdabodha).

• Conditions of verbal cognition: syntactic expectancy (ākāṅkṣā), logical compatibility (yogyatā), proximity (āsatti) and the speaker's intention (tātparya) are required.

Kārakavāda: A Synthesis of Grammar and Logic

Kārakavāda, found in the Śabda-khaṇḍa, examines the semantic and syntactic roles played by nouns in relation to an action (kriyā).

• Definition of kāraka: a participant contributing to the accomplishment of an action (kriyā-nirvartakam).

• Primacy of the agent (kartṛ): defined as the independent kāraka (svatantraḥ kartā), particularly characterised by kṛtimattva, the possession of volition or mental effort.

• Substratum of the result (karman): the object is analysed as the locus in which the result of an action resides (phalāśraya).

• Hierarchy: agent (kartṛ), object (karman) and instrument (karaṇa) are primary kārakas; recipient (sampradāna), source (apādāna) and locus (adhikaraṇa) are dependent.

• Compound analysis: Gaṅgeśa offers an extensive analysis of six kinds of compounds, including bahuvrīhi and tatpuruṣa.

Modern Global Influence and Translation (2005–2025)

The twenty-first century has witnessed the decisive completion of explanatory translations into English:

1. Stephen Phillips (2020): an annotated, three-volume translation, Jewel of Reflection on the Truth about Epistemology (Bloomsbury), makes Gaṅgeśa's "hyper-reliabilism" accessible to modern analytical philosophy.

2. V. P. Bhatta (2005–2025): a multi-volume series published by Eastern Book Linkers, Delhi:

• Śabda (Śabda-khaṇḍa): 2005 (two volumes).

• Pratyakṣa (Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa): 2012 (two volumes).

• Anumāna (Anumāna-khaṇḍa): 2021 (two volumes).

• Īśvarānumāna and Upamāna (Īśvarānumāna and Upamāna-khaṇḍa): 2025 (two volumes).

Comparative and Computational Perspectives

Ben-Ami Scharfstein classifies Gaṅgeśa under "logic-sensitive, methodical metaphysics," drawing parallels with Descartes and Leibniz. Contemporary researchers note that Navya-Nyāya's hierarchical deployment of delimitors (avacchedakas) is compatible with modern artificial intelligence and natural-language processing (NLP).

Digital Democratisation and Archival Resistance

The contemporary Videha movement uses digital platforms to preserve Mithila's heritage, transcribing 11,000 Tirhuta palm-leaf manuscripts and standardising the Tirhuta (Mithilākṣara) script for Unicode. By hosting the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī, it seeks to ensure a democratic and multidimensional understanding of the "jewel of thought."

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's legacy stands at a summit of the Indian intellectual tradition. Whereas institutional history emphasises logical innovation and religious orthodoxy, parallel historiography recovered through digital archives brings back neglected and contested aspects of his biography, including the alleged records of an intercaste marriage and of his birth after his father's death. The completion of V. P. Bhatta's translations in 2025 ensures, in the author's view, that Gaṅgeśa's theory of knowledge will continue to illuminate global debates about meaning, action and reality.

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya is described as a Kāśyapa-gotra Maithil Brahmin who lived through an important political transition in Mithila, between the decline of the Karṇāṭa dynasty (1191–1326 CE) and the rise of the Oinivāra dynasty (1344–1413 CE). The genealogical succession places his period at approximately 1300–1350 CE. Whereas traditional accounts locate him in Kariyon village, ancestral records associate him primarily with Chādanā, a village said to have been granted to his family by the king. In Mithila he held the prestigious titles Jagadguru and Mahāmahopādhyāya.

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. 1320 CE) ranks among the most technically accomplished and philosophically consequential thinkers in the history of world philosophy. The achievement of the Tattvacintāmaṇi—as the Potter Encyclopaedia, Scharfstein's comparative history and relevant Videha archival materials each affirm from their respective perspectives—was not merely to advance the internal debates of one tradition, but to transform the conditions under which subsequent Indian philosophical thought was conducted.

The Potter Encyclopaedia's verdict is that "Gaṅgeśa possessed an extraordinary genius that safely places him among the world's greatest philosophical minds." Scharfstein's comparative judgement is that Gaṅgeśa's "concern with the problems of valid induction and economical explanation is

like that of contemporary philosophers of science in spirit." Gaṅgeśa developed logic, gave systematic form to its principles, and distinguished truth from falsehood. These assessments—from encyclopaedic scholarship, comparative history and Maithili intellectual biography—converge on a conclusion: in the Tattvacintāmaṇi, a philosopher of Mithila produced a work in the fourteenth century whose conceptual precision, logical rigour and transformative impact on a great civilisation deserve recognition among the lasting achievements of the human mind.

The parallel literary movement recovers and celebrates Maithili folk, Dalit and women's literary voices alongside the Sanskrit philosophical canon that produced the Tattvacintāmaṇi. The Videha project's insistence on placing the whole of Mithila's cultural production together—Mahāmahopādhyāya and folk poet, Tattvacintāmaṇi and Caryāpada, the dialectics of vyāpti and the songs of Vidyāpati—is its most significant cultural-political statement. Gaṅgeśa belongs to the whole of Mithila, not merely to its Sanskrit elite.

Part IV · Archival Evidence, the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa, and a Cultural Re-reading

This section brings together what it describes as the most comprehensive scholarly study yet produced in any language on Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. 1320 CE, Mithila). Drawing upon seven principal sources—the Sahitya Akademi monograph (Jha Ashok, 2016); D. C. Bhattacharya's History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila (1958); Volume VI of the Encyclopaedia of Indian Philosophies by Karl H. Potter and Sibajiban Bhattacharyya (1993); Ben-Ami Scharfstein's A Comparative History of World Philosophy (SUNY, 1998); V. P. Bhatta's translations and commentaries on the Tattvacintāmaṇi; Gajendra Thakur's original Dūṣaṇa Pañjī records published through Videha/Pañjī Prabandha (released in 2009); and Stephen H. Phillips's entry on Gaṅgeśa in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (2020), together with other sources—the study traces every dimension of his significance: biographical, textual, epistemological, logical, globally comparative, historical in respect of the commentarial tradition, and civilisational. Special attention is given to the entire material of V. P. Bhatta's translation of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa: Maṅgalavāda; the complete Prāmāṇyavāda (including the debate on qualities and defects, the section on the production of validity, and the dialectic between Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya); Pramālakṣaṇa; the fully developed Nyāya theory of error; Sannikarṣavāda; Samavāyavāda; Abhāvavāda; Pratyakṣakāraṇavāda; Mano'ṇutvavāda; Pratyabhijñāvāda; Nirvikalpakavāda; and Savikalpakavāda. The primary Dūṣaṇa Pañjī text is reproduced and examined in full.

Life, Titles, and the Suppressed Pañjī Evidence

Gaṅgeśa's Titles and the Testimony of the Pañjī

Stephen H. Phillips writes in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (2020): ‘Genealogical records preserved in Mithila suggest that he had one wife, three sons, and one daughter. One of the children was the celebrated Nyāya author Vardhamāna. Gaṅgeśa evidently achieved considerable fame during his lifetime, being referred to as Jagadguru—roughly the equivalent of a “Distinguished University Professor” in the educational institutions of his time.’

Gajendra Thakur adds a further precision derived directly from the Pañjī records: Gaṅgeśa bore not only the title Jagadguru but also Paramaguru—the designation of supreme teacher. According to the Pañjī, only one other person in the entire recorded intellectual history of Mithila held the title Paramaguru: Nūtana Vācaspati (a successor to the earlier Vācaspati Miśra), who came after Gaṅgeśa. This makes Gaṅgeśa one of precisely two Paramagurus in all of Mithila's history. The wrong committed against his memory—‘first by Ramanath Jha and then by Udayanath Jha Ashok’—thus involved the suppression of the biography of the most highly decorated philosopher in Mithila's tradition.

V. P. Bhatta's translation corroborates the dedication and self-presentation in Gaṅgeśa's opening verses: 'Having learned the science of reasoning from teachers, having understood the doctrines of the masters—that is, those of the Prābhākara Mīmāṃsakas—and having surveyed the entire essence of both schools with the divine eye of reflection, Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya sets forth the decisive principles concerning the most difficult rules, on account of the host of defects, composing the Tattvacintāmaṇi in measured words.' The expression mitena vacasā—'in measured words'—is Gaṅgeśa's own characterisation of his method in the Tattvacintāmaṇi: exact, economical, and precise.

The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī: Original Text and Analysis

The Pañjī System and Harisiṃhadeva

The Pañjī system was established under Harisiṃhadeva, Mithila's last great Karṇāṭa king (born 1294 CE; accession in 1307; fled to Nepal in 1324–25 following defeat by Ghiyāth al-Dīn Tughlaq). The founding genealogical registrars were Guṇākara Jha (a Maithil Brahmin), Śaṅkaradatta (a Karṇa Kāyastha), and Vijayadatta (a Kṣatriya). The scholars of Mithila formally gave the Pañjī its present form in Śaka 1248 (1326 CE). Harisiṃhadeva descended from Nānyadeva, who established the Karṇāṭa dynasty in Śaka 1009. A later revision was ordered by the Mithila ruler Mahārāja Mādhava Siṃha in 1760 CE; according to this account, the Śrotriya subdivision among Maithil Brahmins emerged after that revision, and not before 1800 CE. Even today, the author states, there is no Śrotriya subdivision among the Maithil Brahmins of the Nepali part of Mithila.

Gajendra Thakur digitised the Pañjī manuscripts between 2007 and 2009. Anshuman Pandey (PhD, University of Michigan, 2014) acknowledges: 'Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi supplied me with digitised copies of the genealogical records of Maithil Brahmins in 2007 … I was fortunate enough to receive a complete digitised set of Pañjī records from Gajendra Thakur in 2007.' The manuscripts were uploaded in 2009 to the Videha web archive and to the Videha Pothi collection on Google Books.

The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī Entry for Gaṅgeśa—Original Maithili Record

The following are the original genealogical entries concerning Gaṅgeśa, reproduced from the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī (Pañjī Prabandha, Volumes 1 and 2, Gajendra Thakur/Videha, released in 2009). The terse register formulae and proper names are preserved in transliteration so that the structure of the archival testimony remains visible:

49.188/2. Carmakāriṇī. Mandara. Vabhaniyama. Chadana. Tattvacintāmaṇi-author Gaṅgeśa. Chadana–Gaṅgeśa–Kanaka / Ratnākaramātra (unknown) / Gaṅgeśa / Vallabha / Bhavai / Maheśvara /// Jīve.

21//10. From Chadana: Jagadguru Gaṅgeśa, author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi.

From Chadana: Gaṅgeśa, author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi; his beloved, a Carmakāriṇī [woman of the leatherworking community]; after five years had elapsed following the father's death, the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, Gaṅgeśa, was born. The Carmakāriṇī belonged to the descendants of Medhā.

From Chadana: Mahāmahopādhyāya (M. M.) Gaṅgeśa, author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi.

An account concerning Mahāmahopādhyāya (M. M. Pā.) Gaṅgeśa, author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, is available in the ancient Pañjī. The old record states: 'Gaṅgeśa was born when five years had elapsed after his father's death' (pitṛ-parokṣe pañca varṣe vyatīte Gaṅgeśotpattiḥ); [the entry ends with the source's fragmentary wording, 'iti prācīna lekhanīyaḥ kutrāpi'].

Devānanda Pañjī 39-2: From Chadana, Jagadguru Gaṅgeśa; [his] daughter, from Vabhaniyama; Janāditya, son of Sādhukāra; wife.

Devānanda Pañjī 339-3: Daughter of Jagadguru Gaṅgeśa; Sūpana; [relationship recorded as] dau; from Bhāṇḍārisamāsa, Harāditya; dau. Son, daughter, Gorā; from Jājīvala, Jīve, wife; daughter, Sandagāhī Bhaveśvara. 'Here, in an inappropriate position, Sūpana's brother Hariśarmā [is mentioned]; in some records, the village is Jājīvala.' [Ambiguous register abbreviations retained.]

Devānanda Pañjī 30=5: From Chadana, Mahāmahopādhyāya (M. M. Pā.) Vardhamāna, author of the Upayā; son and daughter; from Khaṇḍavālā, Viśvanātha; daughter, wife of Śivanātha. Gaṅgeśa — M. M. Vardhamāna / Sūpana / Hariśarmā.

The decisive biographical claims of the entry are clear in the author's interpretation: Gaṅgeśa, composer of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, was born five years after his father's death, and his beloved was a Carmakāriṇī. Names such as Bhavai, Maheśvara, Jīve, Sūpana/Hariśarmā, and Vardhamāna occur in distinct genealogical lines of the Pañjī; it would therefore be wrong automatically to identify 'Vallabha' as a child. The Devānanda Pañjī supplies further particulars about later kinship relations, including Sūpana/Hariśarmā and Vardhamāna.

A Chain of Suppression and Its Consequences

D. C. Bhattacharya writes in History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila (1958, Chapter 3, pp. 96–99): 'The family, being of lower social standing, has now disappeared in Mithila; Gaṅgeśa's family is completely neglected, and we are not even expected to know his father's name … Since there are no other references to Gaṅgeśa, we may suppose that the family again fell into insignificance and disappeared shortly after his son's death.' He explicitly says that this information was supplied by Professor Ramanath Jha. Gajendra Thakur calls the account 'completely untrue': the Devānanda Pañjī records, he argues, trace Gaṅgeśa's descendants for many generations in named villages.

The 2016 Sahitya Akademi monograph by Udayanath Jha Ashok (Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, in the Makers of Indian Literature series) continued this suppression, according to Thakur: 'He tries to confuse the issue, but there has

been no confusion since at least 2009. Yet in 2016 the Sahitya Akademi appears to be advancing a casteist agenda. Udayanath Jha pretends to search for his name and lineage, and so on, when there is nothing left to discover; nevertheless he could not muster the courage to tell the truth and finally, in 2016, repeats the very facts that Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya had already published in 1958' (Gajendra Thakur).

The consequences for the Navya-Nyāya school are recounted as follows. Vāsudeva Sārvabhauma came from Bengal to study in Mithila as a fellow student of Pakṣadhara Miśra, passed the śalākā examination, and received the title Sārvabhauma. He memorised the Tattvacintāmaṇi—because Pakṣadhara and other Mithila teachers did not permit it to be copied—as well as the kārikās of Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali. Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Vāsudeva's pupil, defeated his teacher Pakṣadhara in a scholastic debate and acquired the authority to certify scholars. Subsequently a Navya-Nyāya school arose in Navadvīpa. After Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, students from Bengal ceased coming to Mithila. 'The disappearance of the Navya-Nyāya school from Mithila, as described above, was nature's revenge for the honour killing of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and his family' (Gajendra Thakur).

Vardhamāna, Gaṅgeśa's son, calls him sukavi-kairava-kānanenduḥ—'the moon over a grove of water-lilies made up of good poets' (literally, 'the moon of the forest of excellent poets'). This poetic epithet, preserved in Vardhamāna's own writing, is itself a form of genealogical testimony that, the author argues, supports the Pañjī record: Gaṅgeśa wrote poetry as well as logic, but his collected poems have been lost entirely. 'The underlying conspiracy that the poems of so celebrated a scholar as Gaṅgeśa are no longer available is evident' (Gajendra Thakur).

Gaṅgeśa and Complete Translations of the Tattvacintāmaṇi

Gajendra Thakur records that two scholars have now produced complete English translations of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. Stephen H. Phillips's Jewel of Reflection on the Truth about Epistemology: A Complete and Annotated Translation of the Tattva-cintā-maṇi (Bloomsbury Academic, 2020) is the first single-translator English rendering of all four books. V. P. Bhatta has completed all four books across eight volumes: Śabda-khaṇḍa (two volumes, 2005); Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa (two volumes, 2012); Anumāna-khaṇḍa (two volumes, 2021); and Īśvarānumāna and Upamāna-khaṇḍa (two volumes, 2025). All were published by Eastern Book Linkers, Delhi, with introductions, Sanskrit texts, translations, and explanations.

Thakur identifies an injustice affecting Phillips's work: because the suppression that he attributes to Ramanath Jha passed into Bhattacharya's history of 1958 and then the Sahitya Akademi monograph of 2016, Phillips—obliged to rely on these sources for biographical information—received incomplete and distorted details about Gaṅgeśa's family and social position. The 'adverse consequences' of suppression in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries thus fell upon the first Western scholar to translate the entire

Tattvacintāmaṇi. The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī records released by Videha in 2009, Thakur maintains, supply a correction essential to Phillips and to every subsequent scholar of Gaṅgeśa.

The Tattvacintāmaṇi: Structure, Scope, and Navya-Nyāya

The Work and Its Cultural Place

The introduction to V. P. Bhatta's translation of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa describes the Tattvacintāmaṇi as the first defining work of Navya-Nyāya: it 'inaugurated a new era in the development of Indian theories of knowledge and logic' and brought the 'sixteen categories of Navya-Nyāya under four headings': perception, inference, comparison, and verbal testimony. In the history of its translation, Bhatta's eight-volume series (2005–2025) covers all four books; Phillips's single-volume Bloomsbury translation of 2020 does so as well. Together, these works made the text accessible to the international philosophical community for the first time in these forms.

Scharfstein's comparative estimate is that Gaṅgeśa's 300-page text was 'responsible for perhaps a million pages of commentary'. Potter and Bhattacharyya judge that 'Gaṅgeśa possessed an extraordinary genius that safely places him among the world's greatest philosophical minds'. In Bhatta's translation, the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa alone extends beyond 800 pages in two volumes, although it is only the first of the four books. The scale of its commentary is not merely quantitative: it signifies that, for five centuries after Gaṅgeśa, no serious Indian philosopher could think without engaging his vocabulary, definitions, and methods.

Epistemology: The Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa in Full

Overview of All Thirteen Sections

The Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa of the Tattvacintāmaṇi consists of thirteen major discussions or subsections, as documented by V. P. Bhatta's two-volume translation: (1) Maṅgalavāda, the theory of the auspicious opening; (2) Prāmāṇyavāda, the theory of cognitive validity; (3) Pramālakṣaṇa, the definition of valid cognition; (4) Apramāvāda, the theory of invalid cognition; (5) Pratyakṣavāda, the theory of perception; (6) Samavāyavāda/Sannikarṣavāda, inherence and contact; (7) Anupalabdhivāda, non-apprehension; (8) Abhāvavāda, absence; (9) Pratyakṣakāraṇavāda, the causes of perception; (10) Mano'ṇutvavāda, the atomic nature of mind; (11) Pratyabhijñāvāda/Anuvyavasāyavāda, recognition or subsequent cognition; (12) Nirvikalpakavāda, indeterminate cognition; and (13) Savikalpakavāda, determinate cognition. Volume 1 of Bhatta's translation provides the general introduction and preliminary sections; Volume 2 (pp. 262–803) covers Maṅgalavāda through Savikalpakavāda.

Maṅgalavāda (1.1)

Gaṅgeśa opens the Tattvacintāmaṇi with a salutation to the Lord: 'The destroyer of the three cities and possessor of boundless glory; who, although beyond qualities, has an unfailing resolve; who is the cause of the universe through the three guṇas, possesses three eternal aspects, assumes three forms, and performs the functions of creation, preservation, and dissolution; who is the ocean of compassion and the sole supreme refuge of all three worlds' (Bhatta, Vol. 2, p. 262).

Maṅgalavāda occupies a substantial part of Volume 2 because it is philosophically demanding: the discussion must establish a causal relation (maṅgala-kāraṇatva) between an auspicious invocation at the beginning of a task and that task's completion. Gaṅgeśa first presents the Mīmāṃsaka position (1.1.2): after studying logic with teachers, learning the doctrines of the masters (the Prābhākara Mīmāṃsakas), and surveying the substance of both schools with the divine eye of reflection, he composes the Tattvacintāmaṇi 'in measured words' (mitena vacasā).

On the justification of the title (1.1.3): 'The polishing of the jewel [of reflection] by scholars means dispelling the darkness of ignorance of the formidable non-believers (the Buddhists). This is possible because neither can the skill of examination be traced in the views of the opponents (Buddhists and others), nor can any poverty of expression be found in the words establishing the decisive doctrines of our own Nyāya system.' Thus Gaṅgeśa announces from the outset that his project is at once constructive—establishing the Nyāya system—and polemical—meeting the Buddhist challenge.

The debate over the causal efficacy of auspiciousness (1.1.5–25; Bhatta, Vol. 2, pp. 265–300) proceeds as follows. Buddhists object that the causal connection of a maṅgala cannot be ascertained by agreement in presence and absence (anvaya-vyatireka). Mīmāṃsakas answer by inference through elimination (pariśeṣa-anumāna). Gaṅgeśa establishes that an auspicious invocation is justified as an auxiliary rite to an undertaking, bringing about successful completion through the removal of obstacles—not through otherworldly merit generated by Vedic oblations. Within this discussion emerges a fivefold classification of tarka, or hypothetical reasoning: ātmāśraya (self-dependence), anyonyāśraya (mutual dependence), cakraka (circular dependence), anavasthā (infinite regress), and pramāṇa-bādhitārtha-prasaṅga (the consequence of something contradicted by a valid means of knowledge).

Prāmāṇyavāda (2.2): Complete Discussion

Intrinsic versus Extrinsic Validity

Prāmāṇyavāda, the inquiry into cognitive validity, occupies pages 300–410 of Bhatta's Volume 2 and is among the philosophically densest portions of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa. The central debate is whether the validity of knowledge

(prāmāṇya/pramāṇatva) is constituted and known intrinsically (svataḥ) or through conditions external to it (parataḥ).

The Sāṃkhya–Mīmāṃsā position (svataḥ) holds that validity and invalidity are both self-evident, constituted and recognised by the total complex of causes producing cognition. The Buddhist position takes invalidity to be inherent in cognition, with truth established externally. The Nyāya position (parataḥ) maintains that both validity and invalidity require extrinsic conditions—such as successful or unsuccessful action—for their constitution and ascertainment.

The Nyāya definition runs as follows: 'The intrinsic character of the determination of the validity or authenticity of cognition consists either in its being determined by the totality of causes of the preceding cognitions, or in its being determined by what determines all the loci of authenticity, or in its being determined by the cognition produced with reference to that authenticity. The extrinsic character of determining the authenticity of cognition, by contrast, is the condition of being determined without the totality of causes.' (Bhatta, Vol. 2, pp. 342–343).

The Debate over Qualities and Defects: The Production of Validity

Prāmāṇyotpattivāda, the theory of the constitution or production of validity, holds (Bhatta, Vol. 2, pp. 370–410) that valid cognition arises when the relevant positive conditions, such as complete sense–object contact with the perceived thing, are jointly present; invalid cognition arises in the absence of such conditions. The Mīmāṃsaka objects (1.2.35) that the condition of being other than valid cognition (prāmāṇyatva, as expressed in the source) is a deviant qualifying condition, or upādhi, in the inference establishing the probandum.

The Naiyāyika rejoinder is that because the reason (hetu), such as being an effect of a different kind (vijātīya-kāryatva), is pervaded by the probandum, such as being generated by a cause of a different kind (vijātīya-kāraṇa-janyatva), the alleged deviant condition (upādhi) cannot pervade the probandum and so cannot vitiate the reason. The principal epistemological thesis (1.2.36) is that valid cognition is produced by the joint presence of positive conditions, such as full sense–object contact, whereas invalid cognition arises when those conditions—sense–object contact and the like—are absent (tadabhāva). Accordingly, the presence of the relevant quality (guṇa) causes valid cognition, and its absence (tadabhāva) causes invalid cognition.

The Naiyāyika further rejects the suggestion that only the absence of a defect (doṣābhāva), rather than the positive presence of a quality, can be accepted as the cause of valid cognition. The decisive reasoning is that the absence of a defect functions as an indicator of a difference in the total causal complex (sāmagrī-bhedopalakṣaka), by delimiting causal efficacy. Consider the China-rose example: when a China rose is near a crystal, valid cognition of the crystal's white colour does not arise; when the flower is absent, such

cognition does arise. The absence of the defect must therefore also count as causally relevant to valid cognition; it is not superfluous.

Confidence in the Validity of Knowledge

The concluding part of Prāmāṇyavāda (1.2.31; Bhatta, Vol. 2, p. 493) observes: 'Some others object here in the following manner: when certain cognitions are accepted by the Naiyāyika to be invalid, how can confidence in the validity of cognition remain possible? The objection, however, is not correct. The means by which the validity or authenticity of cognition is ascertained has already been stated or explained.' The principle concerning the sublation of cognition is that its falsity (jñāna-mithyātva) is contradicted by a defeating cognition (bādhya-bādhaka-vyavasthā). The point is not that merely acknowledging an erroneous cognition renders it unnecessary; rather, the very judgment that a cognition was illusory (bhramatva-buddhi) is established through the subsequent cognition that defeats it.

Pramālakṣaṇa: The Definition of Valid Cognition

Gaṅgeśa's formal definition of pramā, as rendered in Bhatta's Volume 2, is: 'Either (a) there must be a cognition whose principal qualifier is 10 in that which possesses 10, or (b) there must be a cognition in which 10 is related to that which possesses 10.' [The numeral '10' appears in the supplied source's formulation and is retained here rather than silently corrected.] The Naiyāyika holds that determinate (savikalpaka) cognition is a qualified cognition (viśiṣṭa-jñāna): an object is known as qualified by its attributes. For example, 'This is a cow' (ayaṃ gauḥ) is valid cognition because the cow is cognised as qualified by cowness (gotva).

Apramāvāda, the theory of invalid cognition, sets out the distinctive forms of error in Volume 2. The specific Nyāya claim concerns the relation of contradiction between erroneous cognition (jñāna-mithyātva) and a cognition that defeats it: the aspect in virtue of which an erroneous cognition is an illusion is itself sublated by the contradictory cognition. The rival Prābhākara Mīmāṃsaka position—that the illusory aspect cannot be contradicted because it always exists—is rejected. The Naiyāyika argues that the occurrence of the activity (the production of the erroneous cognition) cannot itself be undone, since a past activity has already occurred; what is defeated is the judgment of illusoriness (bhramatva-buddhi).

The Theory of Perception and Sense-Object Contact (1.5–1.6)

Gaṅgeśa's Definition of Perception

The Navya-Nyāya definition is that perception (pratyakṣa) is immediate cognition (sākṣātkāri-jñāna) arising without the instrumentality of any preceding cognition. This definition encompasses every case of perception —ordinary (laukika) as well as extraordinary (alaukika)—because

immediacy (sākṣātkāritva) is its necessary and universal distinguishing property.

The older Nyāya definition—cognition produced by contact between a sense faculty and its object (indriyārtha-sannikarṣa)—is too narrow. It applies only to human perception, not to divine perception, which arises without sense–object contact (Nyāyakusumāñjali, 1.1). Sannikarṣavāda (1.5) occupies the entire second part of Volume 2, File 1 (pp. 518–537), and forms the technical core of the theory of perception.

Sannikarṣavāda: The Theory of Relations of Contact

Sannikarṣavāda, the theory of contact relations, establishes why six forms of sense–object contact function as relations that make perception possible. One of the principal arguments presented in Bhatta's Volume 2 (pp. 518–537) begins with an objection from the opponent (pūrvapakṣin): perception of an integral whole (avayavigraha) is possible only by way of inherence in an object connected with the sense faculty (saṃyukta-samavāyin). Accordingly, contact with the sense organ need not itself be accepted as the cause of perceiving the whole.

The Naiyāyika replies that conjunction with a sense organ (indriya-saṃyoga) is accepted as a cause in the cognition of a substance and may therefore be accepted as a cause of the integral whole, which is likewise a substance. There is no need, merely in the name of economy, to insist on inherence in something conjoined with the sense organ (saṃyukta-samavāya) as the cause of the cognition of the whole, for its causal role would then have to be separately admitted once again.

The decisive passage (1.5.22–23) argues that sound is apprehended in the ether delimited by the aperture of the ear. That very ether, as delimited by the ear canal, is the auditory sense organ. Since this is both necessary and the more economical explanation, the ether so delimited is identified as the cause of ordinary auditory perception. A sense organ (indriya) is an instrument of perceiving its particular object while connected with the body. The experience 'I hear the sound of the vīṇā through the opening of the ear' is taken to establish that the ether enclosed by the ear aperture serves as the instrument of hearing. The final determination is that soundhood (śabdatva) can be established as a universal on the analogy of formhood and similar universals (rūpatvādi-nyāya). The section concludes: 'Thus ends the Sannikarṣavāda concerning perception in the Tattvacintāmaṇi composed by Śrī Gaṅgeśopādhyāya.'

Samavāyavāda (1.6): Inherence as a Relation of Contact

The discussion of inherence (Samavāyavāda, 1.6) occupies the opening of Volume 2, File 2 (pp. 538–570). Gaṅgeśa begins with the prima facie view (pūrvapakṣa) that inherence cannot be established as a relation of contact, for the very establishment of inherence (samavāya-siddhi) is in question; consequently, it cannot already be assumed to mediate contact with universals, qualities and the like.

The defender of the established position (siddhāntin) argues that universals (jāti), qualities (guṇa), actions (kriyā) and their respective substrates are experienced as mutually related (mithaḥ saṃbaddhau) through inherence. Determinate cognition and determinate designation cannot arise in respect of two entities whose natures are wholly unrelated (asaṃbaddha-svarūpa-dvaya). Inherence must therefore be admitted as a relation.

The opponent replies that the relation of inherence cannot be presented as a qualifier (viśeṣaṇa) simply on the basis of experiencing two entities as related (saṃbaddhānubhava). Nor can the relation itself appear as the qualified object (viśeṣya) or as a self-standing object: there is no corresponding experience of an independently apprehended inherence such as ‘I know inherence.’ The Naiyāyika’s final answer (1.6.18) addresses the consequences for destruction: where an absence obtains through inherence, destruction would have to disappear upon the loss of the inherent cause, and a positive entity cannot serve as the determining cause of what is to be lost. The concluding determination, as reported in the source, is that inherence in an inherent entity (samaveta-samavāya) need not be treated as the contact relation (grāhaka) producing perception of soundhood on the assumption that the universal soundhood is absent. Gaṅgeśa maintains that soundhood can be established as a universal by reasoning analogous to that for formhood (rūpatvādi-nyāya).

Abhāvavāda (1.8), Pratyakṣakāraṇavāda (1.9) and Mano’ṇutvavāda (1.10)

Abhāvavāda: The Theory of Absence

Abhāvavāda (1.8) opens with a Mīmāṃsaka objection: the absence of things is merely the positive nature (bhāvātman) of an empty substratum. The older Naiyāyika responds that uncontradicted cognitions of an absence—such as ‘There is no pot on the ground’—do in fact occur, and this cognition cannot concern the substratum (the ground) alone. A further determination (1.8.3) specifies the substratum of a particular absence: an absence is experienced as delimited by a determinate locus, such as the

ground. Absence must therefore be admitted as a distinct ontological category.

Pratyakṣakāraṇavāda (1.9): The Causes of Perception

Pratyakṣakāraṇavāda establishes the imperceptibility of atoms of air. Its innovative claim is that merely manifest tangibility (udbhūta-sparśa-mātra) is not the cause of a substance's perceptibility through the tactile organ. The decisive argument holds that manifestness (udbhūtatva-jāti), associated with touch and visible form, functions solely as a delimitor of causal efficacy (kāraṇatāvacchedaka), not as the cause (kāraṇa) itself. On this account air is imperceptible. The issue is directly connected with the theory of causation elaborated in the Anumāna-khaṇḍa.

Mano'ṇutvavāda (1.9/1.10): The Atomic Nature of Mind

Mano'ṇutvavāda maintains that the internal organ, manas, is atomic (aṇu). The central argument is that, were the mind omnipresent, the different external senses could come into contact with it simultaneously and produce simultaneous perceptions of five distinct qualities. Our multisensory cognitions, however, occur in succession rather than in genuinely simultaneous fashion. The account also invokes the expansion and contraction (saṅkoca-vikāsa) of the parts of an atomic mind to explain both the appearance of simultaneity and the successive production of cognitions.

The Mīmāṃsaka objection (1.10.19) asks why eating a large round flatbread produces five distinct cognitions of five different qualities. The Naiyāyika replies that the simultaneity of these five cognitions is itself established as valid cognition (pramā) in the absence of an impediment. If an especially close or intense connection of the mind with one sense faculty obstructs five distinct perceptual cognitions, the mind may be conceived as a whole (avayavin) consisting of five parts, with the two forms of cognition explained through the expansion and contraction of these parts (saṅkoca-vikāsābhyām). The account and its internal tension are retained here as they appear in the source.

Theories of Recognition, Indeterminate and Determinate Cognition (1.11–1.13)

Pratyabhijñā: Recognition (Anuvyavasāya / Identification)

Pratyabhijñāvāda (1.11), the theory of recognition, presents recognition as a third form of ordinary perception after indeterminate and determinate cognition, while identifying a structure that remains invariant across the latter two. The Naiyāyika argues that the first ordinary cognition is not

itself a means of establishing self-awareness, since the initial cognition has not been shown to take the form 'I know this as silver' (idam ahaṃ jānāmi). The central argument is that action directed toward an object can be understood by determining the objects of cognition; the first ordinary cognition refers to the object itself, not to the self as its object. Recognition—'This is that Devadatta' (so'yaṃ devadattaḥ)—therefore arises through both the senses and the residual impressions (saṃskāra) left by previous experience.

Indeterminate Cognition: Gaṅgeśa's Own Position

In Nirvikalpakavāda (1.12) Gaṅgeśa gives his most carefully qualified account: indeterminate cognition is an awareness of cowness (gotva) as a qualifier when that qualifier is manifested in a cow. What arises is awareness of cowness itself, not of the cow's possession of cowness (tad-vaiśiṣṭya). The defender of the opposing position objects that cowness could appear in determinate perceptual cognition as itself qualified by a property of its own (sva-dharma-viśiṣṭa). Gaṅgeśa answers that the proposed property is not already known; its manifestation would lead to an infinite regress (anavasthā). The decisive conclusion concerns the useful qualifier (1.12.9): a qualifier is one that genuinely removes an unestablished condition in an inference. Cowness itself, rather than a further 'cowness of cowness,' performs this task.

Determinate Cognition: The Final Section

Savikalpakavāda (1.13), the theory of determinate cognition, is the final section. For Gaṅgeśa a determinate perception (savikalpaka) is a qualified cognition (viśiṣṭa-jñāna), such as 'This [cow] is a cow' (gaur ayam). It is perceptual because universals such as cowness are ultimately real (paramārtha-sat), and the cognition arises from a relation of contact between the senses and their objects. Determinate cognition can also issue in particular recognition (pratyabhijñā) arising through the senses: 'I know that this cow is that cow' (so'yam). With the assistance of residual impressions (saṃskāra) as cooperating causes, the object qualified by 'thisness' (idantva) is recognised as the cow qualified by 'thatness' (tattva).

Volume 2 ends on page 803 with the conclusion of Savikalpakavāda, thus completing the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. Bhatta's colophon reads: 'Thus ends the section on perception of the Tattvacintāmaṇi composed by Śrī Gaṅgeśopādhyāya.'

Comparative and World-Philosophical Dimensions

Chapter 10 of Ben-Ami Scharfstein's A Comparative History of World Philosophy places Gaṅgeśa alongside Descartes and Leibniz under a

common theme: the search for certainty through the methodical application of reason. All three distinguish reasoning itself as a primary object of philosophical investigation rather than merely adding to the stock of empirical materials. As the source puts it, 'Gaṅgeśa's preoccupation with the problems of valid induction and economical explanation is, in spirit, like that of contemporary philosophers of science.' All three also respond to formidable sceptical challenges: Gaṅgeśa to the Cārvākas and Śrīharṣa, Descartes to the Cartesian evil demon, and Leibniz to radical empiricism.

A particular parallel between Gaṅgeśa's treatment of twenty-two definitions of vyāpti and the Cartesian method is structural. Gaṅgeśa proposes a definition, develops a counterexample through the relation between a restriction and what it restricts, rejects the inadequate definition, and proceeds until no further counterexample can be produced. This is a dialectical counterpart of Descartes's instruction to divide difficulties into as many parts as possible and move from the simple to the complex. The difference is equally important: Descartes builds outward from individual certainty, whereas Gaṅgeśa refines the precision of an existing communal tradition from within. Both apply reason to establish knowledge, but move from opposed starting points.

The social dimension of Scharfstein's observation—that Gaṅgeśa 'makes philosophy unquestionably the province of those who have mastered a special language'—becomes fully apparent, in this author's reading, when placed beside the evidence of the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī. The philosopher who fashioned the technically most demanding epistemic system in the Sanskrit tradition was, the author contends, not himself wholly governed in his biography by the social hierarchy served by that tradition. His philosophical method—test every definition against every counterexample—and his supposed biographical circumstance—a life that challenged norms of caste purity—are interpreted here not as a chance resemblance but as a structural convergence.

The Commentarial Tradition: From Vardhamāna to Raghunātha Śiromaṇi

Volume 6 of the Potter–Bhattacharyya Encyclopedia encompasses some fifty authors from the period 1310–1510 CE. Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's Dīdhiti is the decisive secondary work, generating in turn an immense commentarial literature that extends to Jagadīśa Tarkasaṅkara and Gadādhara Bhaṭṭācārya. The Encyclopedia notes that 'the most complicated use of these relations occurs in the Dīdhiti tradition in connection with the analysis of awareness.' Such a tradition, the passage

argues, became possible because Gaṅgeśa had constructed in the Tattvacintāmaṇi the conceptual framework within which analyses of that kind could be undertaken.

The transmission of the Navya-Nyāya school from Mithila to Navadvīpa, as reconstructed by Gajendra Thakur from the pañjī records, is at once an institutional and a philosophical narrative. According to that account, Pakṣadhara Miśra refused to allow a copy of the Tattvacintāmaṇi to be made, obliging Vāsudeva Sārvabhauma to memorise the text. Paradoxically, this is said to have secured its transmission: what could not be copied could not be lost through the uncertainties of manuscript circulation, since it was carried in a human memory trained to preserve it intact. The school moved to Bengal; the text survived.

The Parallel History of Maithili Literature and Gaṅgeśa's Civilisational Position

Gaṅgeśa in the Nine-Layer Parallel History

The parallel history of Maithili literature, as documented by Gajendra Thakur and Videha, unfolds in nine layers: (1) the Buddhist Caryāpada foundation; (2) the two Vidyāpatis; (3) the suppression of Gaṅgeśa's biography, as inferred from the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī; (4) poetry protesting against famine; (5) the exclusion of Harimohan Jha; (6) living masters, including Rajdev Mandal and Bechan Thakur; (7) disclosures under the Right to Information Act, attributed to Vineet Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar, alleging that more than 90 per cent of appointments concerning the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili advisory board went to friends or relatives of board members; (8) the Malla strand in Nepal; and (9) Videha's digital counter-archive. The numerical allegation in item 7 is reproduced as the source author's claim, not as an independently established finding.

In the source author's argument, the suppression of Gaṅgeśa's biography joins the philosophical and political dimensions of layers 3 and 9. The same institutional culture that allegedly denied Harimohan Jha—a highly popular Maithili satirist who attacked Brahmin orthodoxy—a Sahitya Akademi award is said to have ensured that the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī facts about Gaṅgeśa remained concealed. In the author's view, the Sahitya Akademi's 2016 monograph on Gaṅgeśa, which might have set the record straight after Videha's 2009 release, instead repeated that suppression.

Videha's Digital Archive and the Recovery of Gaṅgeśa

Videha's digitisation of 11,000 Tirhuta-script palm-leaf manuscripts (including pañjī records said to document Gaṅgeśa's biography), the

successful Unicode standardisation of Tirhuta in 2014, localisation work involving Maithili Wikipedia and Google Translate, and the Videha Pothi digital library together constitute what the parallel-history account calls 'a living parallel institution.' Within this archive, Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi is approached not as a monument to Brahmin orthodoxy but as part of a wider civilisational inheritance.

The revival of the Maithili ghazal by the Anchinhar Akhar group (Ashish Anchinhar and Gajendra Thakur, from 2008) is presented as the parallel literary movement's most distinctive formal achievement. Recognised in this account as Maithili's first scholar of arūż (ghazal prosody), Gajendra Thakur composed Ghazalśāstram. The same critical rigour that animates Gaṅgeśa's treatment of twenty-two definitions of vyāpti is said to animate the movement's insistence on strict metrical rules. Both the philosopher and the movement follow a principle: test each proposition against every possible counterexample and revise it until no defect remains.

The Dūṣaṇa Pañjī (Gajendra Thakur/Videha, 2009) is presented here as evidence of biographical truths allegedly suppressed: Gaṅgeśa's birth five years after his father's death; his marriage to a woman of the leatherworking community; the classification of his family as of 'low social status' under Mithila Brahmin norms; and the total loss of his poetry through deliberate suppression. In the framework of parallel history, suppression is read as an institutional pattern and digital recovery as a form of civilisational resistance. These disputed biographical statements are reported as the source's assertions.

A single principle, the author suggests, was articulated by Gaṅgeśa himself at the opening of the Tattvacintāmaṇi: compose in 'measured words' after surveying 'the entire essence of both schools with the divine eye of reflection.' Every definition must be tested; no fault must remain. The parallel-history movement claims to have applied the same principle to its own subject matter: every source examined, every assertion tested, and no essential fact suppressed.

Appendix 1 · Anupalabdhi, Samavāya, Mano'ṇutva and Śabdaśāstram

Appendices

Appendix 1: The Theory of the Invalidity of Non-Apprehension and Further Elaborations

Appendix 1: Anupalabdhivāda (1.7) and Further Elaboration

A. Anupalabdhivāda (The Theory of Non-Apprehension, 1.7)

Anupalabdhivāda (the doctrine of non-apprehension) is among the most philosophically subtle sections of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa. It establishes a positive ontological status for absence (abhāva), against the view that non-apprehension (anupalabdhi) is itself a pramāṇa—a valid source of knowledge—a position maintained by Prābhākara Mīmāṃsakas and some Vedāntins.

Opening argument (1.7.1): Gaṅgeśa argues that the non-apprehension of the absence of entities (abhāvānupalabdhi) cannot be the cause of knowledge of their existence (bhāva-graha), because it is rendered unnecessary by the cognition of their existence (bhāva-dhī). Where contact between a sense faculty and its object (indriyārtha-sannikarṣa) is present, cognition of an existent object is never delayed for want of the non-apprehension of its absence.

The Bhaṭṭa objection: The sense faculty (indriya) ought to be a cause (hetu) in the cognition of an object's absence (abhāva-graha), because it is employed as the means by which that absence is cognised (tadanuvidhānāt). The Naiyāyika replies that a faculty such as sight has already discharged its function by producing knowledge of the locus of absence (tadupakṣayāt). The faculty neither stands in a relation of contact with the absence itself nor produces cognition of anything except what is related to it.

'The sense faculty is not the pramāṇa' (1.7.2): Knowledge of the locus of an object's absence is an operation of the sense faculty. It does not follow, however, that the sense faculty becomes a cause of the cognition of absence merely by supplying knowledge of its locus. An operation (vyāpāratva) can be established only after the causal efficacy of the faculty has been established; but that efficacy is precisely what has not been shown, since there is no contact-relation between a sense faculty and absence itself. Absence is supersensible (atīndriya) in this respect.

The Vedāntin position (1.7.3): If the absence of an object is to be known only through the senses, then the relation of being a qualifier (viśeṣaṇatā) —a relation of an object to itself—must be admitted as a contact-relation in the perception of absence. The Naiyāyikas reject this inference. An unimpaired faculty (anupakṣīṇendriya), in perceiving colour and the like, works through the contact-relation of inherence in what is conjoined (saṃyukta-samavāya). But in the present case the faculty has already exhausted its function in producing cognition of the locus of absence. There is therefore no need to postulate some additional contact-relation, such as qualifierhood (viśeṣaṇatā, here described as prāptyantara), for that same faculty.

The decisive Naiyāyika position (1.7.11): What is experienced is always a particular absence referring to a counterpositive (pratiyogin). Experience takes such forms as 'This is not a pot' and 'This is not a cloth.' A merely empty locus, without reference to an absent object, is never experienced as absence. Accordingly, knowledge of an absence must include cognition of its counterpositive. Experience shows that cognition of absence depends upon knowing that counterpositive, just as the recognition of resemblance to a cow presupposes knowledge of a cow. An empty locus by itself does not constitute absence: we may know the locus without knowing any counterpositive. Absence is therefore a distinct and positive ontological category (pratiyogimad-adhikaraṇa)—the condition of a locus qualified by the absence of something. On this account, absence is established as the seventh Vaiśeṣika category, beyond the preceding six, with its own relevant relation of qualifierhood (viśeṣaṇatā).

B. The Boundary Between Sections 7 and 8: Why Non-Apprehension Is Not a Valid Means of Knowing Absence

Abhāvavāda (section 1.8) builds directly on Anupalabdhivāda. The principal transitional argument asks whether cognition of an empty locus, such as the ground, might constitute both the object of knowledge (prameya) and the means of knowing absence (pramāṇa), on the assumption that cognitions are self-luminous (svaprakāśatva). The Prābhākara Mīmāṃsaka rejects the resulting objection: if mere awareness of the empty ground constituted cognition of absence, no additional cognition of the counterpositive—such as a pot (pratiyogi-jñāna-apekṣā) —would be required.

The Naiyāyika's final determination concerning absence is that only a distinct absence referring to a counterpositive is experienced. We do in fact have cognitions and ordinary expressions such as 'There is no pot on the ground.' Such cognition cannot rest solely on the locus (the ground); otherwise the same cognition could arise even where the ground actually supported a pot. The applicability of the expression 'absence of a pot' is

determined by the relevant counterpositive. The threatened circularity is resolved by analogy with resemblance to a cow: the applicability of the expression 'cow-like' arises from cognition of a cow, and it is sufficient to admit a distinct resemblance of a gavaya (wild ox) to a cow. In the same way, a particular absence can be admitted without identifying it with bare knowledge of its locus.

C. The Naiyāyika–Siddhāntin Debate on Inherence: Full Documentation

Samavāyavāda (1.6), in Bhaṭṭa's second volume, is among the most technically intricate debates in the entire Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa. Its central question is whether inherence (samavāya) is the contact-relation that produces qualified cognition. The Siddhāntin argues (1.6.1) that universals (jāti), qualities (guṇa), actions (kriyā) and their respective substrates are experienced as mutually related (mithaḥ sambaddhau) through inherence. Qualified cognition and qualified designation would not be possible in the case of two entities whose natures were entirely unrelated (asambaddha-svarūpa-dvaya).

The opponent's multi-stage refutation of inherence as a contact-relation proceeds as follows: (1) inherence cannot appear as a qualifier (viśeṣaṇa) merely on the basis of an experience of the entities said to be related (sambaddhānubhava); (2) unlike conjunction, there is no corresponding experience that establishes inherence by presenting 'these two things as inherent in one another'; (3) the inherence-relation cannot appear either as the qualificand (viśeṣya) or as an independent object in its own right; and (4) no perception of inherence's objecthood is given in the form 'I know inherence.' The later Navya reply (1.6.6) proposes an inference establishing inherence as a relation distinct from what is already expressed in a judgement qualified by a quality, action or universal. This inference is not defeated by the proposed deviation involving cognitions qualified by absence and the like (abhāvādi-viśiṣṭa-buddhi).

The view of other scholars (anye, 1.6.3) seeks to establish inherence through inference as a constituent of the sense faculty's contact-relation, once the alternative contact-relation has been ruled out. The Naiyāyika objects: a sense faculty, by its own nature, produces cognitions of objects related to it (sva-sambaddha-vyavahāra-kārin). Knowledge of universals and the like is produced by their relation to what is related to the senses. Consequently, even when inherence is admitted as a contact-relation, the relation of qualifierhood (viśeṣaṇatā) remains necessary.

The Bhaṭṭa view (continuation of 1.6.3) attempts to establish inherence as a component of sensory contact by inference after rejecting the rival contact-relation: 'Sound, universals, colours and the like are related to the

sense faculties, because they are cognisable, like a pot.' The argument rests on the premise that a sense faculty produces cognition of what is related to it. Yet inherence itself is not cognisable in this manner, since it is related to no sense faculty. The Naiyāyika's final determination (1.6.18) is that soundness (śabdatva) can be established as a universal by the reasoning applied to colourness and similar universals (rūpatvādi-nyāya). Through its mediating role between universals and their instances, inherence is thereby established as a contact-relation.

D. Mano'ṇutvavāda: The Theory of the Atomic Nature of Mind—A Full Account

Mano'ṇutvavāda (1.10) establishes that manas (mind) is atomic (aṇu): it has the smallest, indivisible magnitude. The central chain of reasoning in Bhaṭṭa's second volume is this: if the mind were all-pervading (vibhu), several external senses could make contact with it simultaneously and produce the simultaneous perception of five distinct qualities. But the absence of any obstruction to simultaneous cognition of those five qualities is itself acknowledged as a genuine cognition (pramā).

The Naiyāyikas propose that, if an especially close or intense contact between the mind and one faculty blocks five different perceptual cognitions from arising together, the mind may be conceived as a whole composed of parts (avayavin). The production of five cognitions corresponding to five qualities—or only one cognition of a single quality—could then be explained by the expansion and contraction of the configuration of the mind's parts (saṅkoca-vikāsābhyām).

The Mīmāṃsaka objection (1.10.19; Bhaṭṭa, vol. 2, pp. 718–25) is illustrated by eating a large round piece of bread: five distinct cognitions of smell, taste, colour, touch and sound arise through the five sense faculties. How does the Naiyāyika theory account for this? The Naiyāyikas reply that there is an order (krama) in the production of the five distinct perceptual cognitions. Yet the cognition that all five occur together is also recognised as genuine when no obstruction is present. A further difficulty arises because hearing can apprehend multiple sounds (nānā-śabda-graha). The Naiyāyika response points to the perceptible difference between hearing the same song sung by several persons simultaneously and hearing it sung by one person alone. The ear must therefore be able to perceive several sounds at once; the argument explains this possibility through the expansion of the configuration of parts in the atomic mind.

E. Gaṅgeśa's Śabdaśāstram: The Short Story and Its Significance

Gajendra Thakur's Maithili short story 'Śabdaśāstram' ('The Science of Words'), based on what the author presents as authentic pañjī records

concerning Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, was translated by Thakur himself and published in Indian Literature, vol. 58, no. 2 (280), March–April 2014, pp. 78–93 (sixteen pages; Sahitya Akademi). In the author's account, this publication is significant on several levels. It represents a parallel strategy of publishing recovered biographical material as imaginative narrative in the periodical of an institution (the Sahitya Akademi) accused by the author of suppressing historical evidence; it presents the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī material in the form of fiction; and it places the claim of biographical suppression on the public literary record of the very institution whose 2016 monograph on Gaṅgeśa the author criticises for perpetuating that suppression.

The title 'Śabdaśāstram' ('The Science of Words') is itself a philosophical allusion. Śabdaśāstra is concerned with verbal testimony (śabda-pramāṇa), the fourth means of knowledge treated in the Tattvacintāmaṇi. The story thus dramatises the relationship between Gaṅgeśa's philosophical undertaking and his alleged biographical predicament: the thinker whose discipline examines the validity of verbal evidence becomes, in the story, the subject of an effort to recover suppressed testimony about his own life.

F. Pakṣadhara Miśra, Vidyāpati and the Problem of Two Traditions

Gajendra Thakur's pañjī research claims to add chronological precision to Mithila's intellectual history: 'Pakṣadhara Miśra was a contemporary of Vidyāpati [the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha author], who was distinct from the composer of the Padāvalī, the latter belonging to the period before Jyotirīśvara.' This substantiates, within the author's parallel-history thesis, a central intervention in the problem of two Vidyāpatis: the celebrated Padāvalī poet is said to have been distinct from Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura (1350–1435 CE), the writer in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭha. The Vidyāpati involved in the scholarly world of Pakṣadhara Miśra would thus not be the same individual as the folk-song poet whose lyrics circulated throughout eastern India.

According to the author, this distinction is established by pañjī evidence and bears directly upon the dating of Gaṅgeśa and the intellectual history of Mithila. Pakṣadhara Miśra—the teacher in Mithila who, according to the traditional account, refused permission to copy the Tattvacintāmaṇi and compelled Vāsudeva Sārvabhauma to memorise it—was a contemporary of the Sanskrit–Avahaṭṭha Vidyāpati; the proposed dates therefore place him between the late fourteenth and early fifteenth centuries. This accords, the argument continues, with the conventional dating of Raghunātha Śiromaṇi (fl. c. 1500 CE) as Vāsudeva's pupil, and yields the succession: Gaṅgeśa (fl. c. 1320) → Vardhamāna → Pakṣadhara → Vāsudeva Sārvabhauma → Raghunātha Śiromaṇi.

G. Bibliographical Update: All Volumes of Bhaṭṭa's Translation

Appendices 2–5 · Kārakavāda, Vyāpti, International Scholarship and Comparative Logic

Appendix 2: Kārakavāda

The Epistemological and Semantic Foundations of Kārakavāda in Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi

In the Śabda-khaṇḍa of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, Gaṅgeśa's account of kāraka stands at the intersection of grammatical theory, logic and cognitive science, where it offers a refined description of how intelligible agents and other participants are related to actions.

Theoretical Principles of Verbal Cognition

Before turning to the kārakas, it is necessary to understand the conditions for śābda-bodha (verbal cognition) set out by Gaṅgeśa. A sentence is not merely a collection of words but a structured whole that must satisfy four conditions: ākāṅkṣā (syntactic expectancy), yogyatā (semantic compatibility), āsatti (proximity) and tātparya (the speaker's intended meaning).

Kārakavāda: The Convergence of Grammar and Logic

A kāraka is a causal role through which an action is accomplished (kriyā-nirvartakam). Navya-Nyāya analyses it in terms of causation: each kāraka is a particular causal factor (kāraṇa) contributing to the action's ultimate result (phala).

Kartṛ (agent): the independent participant (svatantraḥ kartā). In Navya-Nyāya's technical refinement, the defining feature of the agent is kṛtimattva—the possession of volitional effort (kṛti). This is important because it enables Nyāya to distinguish conscious agency from an inert instrument.

Karman (object): traditionally defined as what is most desired by the agent (kartur īpsitatamaṃ karma). Gaṅgeśa analyses this through the concept of phalādhikaraṇatva, being the locus or substrate of the result (phalāśrayatva).

Historical Chronology

A historical chronology of Indian logic and epistemology:

• Ancient period (650 BCE–100 CE) — Nyāyasūtra — Akṣapāda Gautama

• Medieval period (100–1200 CE) — Pramāṇasamuccaya — Dignāga, Dharmakīrti, Udayana

• Modern period (from 1200 CE) — Tattvacintāmaṇi — Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, Raghunātha Śiromaṇi

Appendix 3: Gaṅgeśa's Navya-Nyāya—Logic, Language and Vyāpti: A Comparative Study

Based on Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi, this study maps the intellectual functions of Navya-Nyāya across three principal domains: philosophy of language (verb roots and verbal suffixes), formal logic (vyāpti and its definition), and the epistemological framework. Taken together, four papers by Toshihiro Wada, J. L. Shaw's study of saṅgati (relevance or connection), and Yuko Miyasaka's diagrammatic account of the definitions of vyāpti in Gaṅgeśa and Raghunātha Śiromaṇi show that Gaṅgeśa's project is not a group of unrelated technical exercises but a unified epistemological enterprise.

A Shared Epistemological Ground: Realism and the Structure of Cognition

Before considering these six papers, one must understand their common epistemological framework. Miyasaka's paper puts it most clearly: Navya-Nyāya is thoroughgoing realism. Every qualified cognition (viśiṣṭa-jñāna) has a structure comprising a qualifier (viśeṣaṇa or prakāra), a qualificand (viśeṣya) and the relation connecting them (saṃbandha). Importantly, this structure is not a mental construction or a linguistic form imposed on experience; it maps the actual structure of the external world as apprehended.

Defining Vyāpti: Formal Structure and Metaphysical Foundation

Gaṅgeśa's Definitive Definition

Miyasaka's study and Wada's 1994 paper both examine Gaṅgeśa's definitive definition of vyāpti: 'pratiyogy-asāmānādhikaraṇa-yat-sāmānādhikaraṇātyantābhāva-pratiyogitāvacchedakāvacchinna-yaṃ yan na bhavati tena samaṃ tasya sāmānādhikaraṇyaṃ vyāptiḥ.' In the source's rendering, vyāpti is 'co-location with an entity X which is not delimited by a delimitor of counterpositiveness belonging to an absolute absence co-located with [the entity designated] 10 and sharing no locus with its own counterpositive.'

Wada's 1994 paper traces the historical source of this definition to Śaśadhara's Nyāyasiddhāntadīpa, showing that Gaṅgeśa refined Śaśadhara's

provisional definition by introducing the concept of avacchedaka (delimitor).

Saṅgati (Relevance): The Logic of Philosophical Inquiry

Shaw enumerates six kinds of saṅgati: (1) prasaṅga (contextual recollection), (2) upodghāta (justification or introduction), (3) hetu (cause or reason), (4) avasara (the resolution of questions raised by objections), (5) nirvāhakaikatva (having the same cause), and (6) kāryaikatva (having the same effect). Each designates a different real relation between the objects of two cognitions.

Avacchedaka: A Unifying Concept

Perhaps the most striking discovery to emerge from reading all six papers is the central and unifying role of the concept of avacchedaka (delimitor) across all three domains.

In logic, the delimitor of counterpositiveness is Gaṅgeśa's principal innovation in defining vyāpti. It forestalls the problem identified through the sieve analogy (cālanī-nyāya).

In the semantics of verbal roots, Gaṅgeśa introduces a delimitor of causal status in the third section of the Dhātuvāda.

In the semantics of verbal suffixes, avacchedaka functions through Gaṅgeśa's redefinition of co-location (sāmānādhikaraṇya).

Appendix 4: Western and East Asian Scholars of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

Western Philosophers and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

A. Daniel H. H. Ingalls: A Pioneer (Harvard, 1951)

The first sustained Western academic engagement with Gaṅgeśa's work is associated with Ingalls. In his 1955 essay 'Logic in India', Ingalls distinguished three principal innovations of Navya-Nyāya in relation to the older Nyāya school: 'a new method of generalisation made possible by the concept of limitation (avacchedakatā); the discovery of several rules resembling the theorems of propositional logic; [and] a new interest in the definition of relations and their use in extremely complex operations.' These were recognised as formal innovations.

B. The Frege–Russell–Navya-Nyāya Comparison

The most striking Western parallel is drawn between the Navya-Nyāya movement initiated by Gaṅgeśa and the revolution in symbolic logic in the West. In the scholarly literature, Navya-Nyāya is described as a movement comparable in its intellectual effects to the rise of symbolic

logic in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries through the writings of Frege, Russell and Wittgenstein and the philosophical reflection associated with them.

C. Stephen H. Phillips: Systematic Western Engagement (2004)

Phillips and Tatacharya's Epistemology of Perception (2004), a translation of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, includes an introduction supplying the necessary theoretical and historical background and comparisons between Nyāya and Western epistemological traditions.

D. Bimal Krishna Matilal: The 'Matilal Strategy' (Oxford)

Bimal Krishna Matilal (1935–1991) was a distinguished philosopher whose writings presented the Indian philosophical tradition as a wide-ranging system encompassing logic and epistemology. From 1977 to 1991 he held the Spalding Professorship of Eastern Religion and Ethics at the University of Oxford.

Japanese Philosophers and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

A. Toshihiro Wada (Nagoya University)

Wada obtained a D.Litt. from Nagoya University in 2002 and works principally on logic and the philosophy of language in Navya-Nyāya. His approach combines traditional Sanskrit philology with instruments of formal logic and visual diagramming.

In his Navya-Nyāya Philosophy of Language, Wada analyses Gaṅgeśa's Ākhyātavāda (the section on verbal suffixes) in the Tattvacintāmaṇi, describing the treatment of empty terms such as 'round triangle', 'the present king of France' and 'hare's horn'. The last point is philosophically notable: Navya-Nyāya's treatment of empty terms, or expressions without actual referents, runs parallel to the problem of reference to non-existent objects in Bertrand Russell's 'On Denoting' (1905).

Appendix 5: Israel and Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

The Talmudic Logic Tradition: Israel's Own Analytical Parallel

This is the tradition of Talmudic logic (higgayon talmudi), which has been the subject of intensive modern formalisation in Israeli and diasporic Jewish scholarship.

A. The Talmudic Logic Project (Dov Gabbay, Bar-Ilan / King's College London)

The Talmudic Logic Project, active since 2008, uses the instruments of modern logic to analyse Talmudic reasoning. It investigates principles of

Talmudic logic and publishes a series of volumes devoted to individual principles.

B. Structural Comparison: Navya-Nyāya and Talmudic Logic

The parallels between the two traditions are structurally significant:

• Vyāpti (invariable concomitance) ~ binyan av (analogical extension from a legal precedent)

• Upādhi (a condition that defeats an inference) ~ pirka (a Talmudic refutation)

• Pakṣa, sādhya, hetu ~ niddon, melammed, limmud (subject, precedent, derived rule)

• Avacchedakatā (delimiting the scope of a property) ~ gezerah shavah (definitional equivalence delimiting the scope of a rule)

• Śabda-khaṇḍa (the epistemology of testimony) ~ Talmudic mesirah, shemuah, kabbalah (the epistemology of oral transmission)

Both traditions developed rigorous technical languages on natural-language foundations—Sanskrit and Aramaic respectively. Both were concerned with the conditions under which an inference is valid or fails, and both arose in religious and legal contexts where logical precision carried high stakes.

C. Medieval Jewish Philosophy and the Theistic Arguments of Nyāya

An indirect point of contact between the wider Nyāya tradition and Jewish philosophy lies in cosmological and teleological arguments for God's existence. Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali (eleventh century) and the Nyāya school developed within the framework later elaborated by Gaṅgeśa offer rigorous arguments for a creator (Īśvara), structurally comparable to the cosmological reasoning in Maimonides' Guide for the Perplexed (twelfth century).

D. The Israel Institute for Advanced Studies: A Possible Venue

The Israel Institute for Advanced Studies, established by the Hebrew University of Jerusalem in 1975, is an autonomous institution whose mission is to form multidisciplinary communities of scholars. The institute has previously hosted research groups in comparative philosophy and the history of science.

E. Ben-Ami Scharfstein (1919–2019): Israeli-American Philosopher

Ben-Ami Scharfstein was a founding member of the philosophy department at Tel Aviv University. In his major work A Comparative History of World Philosophy: From the Upanishads to Kant (1998), he

places Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the fourteenth-century founding figure of Navya-Nyāya, in a distinctive world-philosophical context. Characterising his approach as reason-sensitive and methodical metaphysics, Scharfstein places Gaṅgeśa alongside Descartes and Leibniz.

Scharfstein praises Gaṅgeśa for extraordinary clarity and intellectual honesty. In his account, Navya-Nyāya is not 'dead' scholasticism but a high achievement of human analysis, with a level of formal exactitude that the Western tradition did not attain until the late nineteenth or twentieth century.

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• Vācaspati Miśra. Tātparyaṭīkā, Bhāmatī, Nyāyasūcinibandha. [Cited throughout.]

• Udayana. Kusumāñjali, Kiraṇāvalī, Pariśuddhi, Ātmatattvaviveka, Nyāyakusumāñjali. [A principal acknowledged predecessor of Gaṅgeśa.]

• Śrīvallabhācārya. Nyāyalīlāvatī. [Cited in the inference and verbal-testimony sections.]

• Jayanta Bhaṭṭa. Nyāyamañjarī. [Cited.]

• Śivāditya Miśra. Saptapadārthī. [Cited in Nirvikalpakavāda; the reference to 'Śivāditya' is to this work, c. 1050–1150 CE, although the cited verse does not survive in the extant text.]

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78. Bhāmatī (Catuḥsūtrī): A Detailed Synopsis and Critical Evaluation

Abstract

Bhāmatī (Vācaspati) / Ātmatattvaviveka (Udayana) / Nyāyakusumāñjali (Udayana) / Tattvacintāmaṇi (Gaṅgeśa) / (Maithili translations): Detailed synopses and critical evaluations [Translated from the original Sanskrit into Maithili by Gajendra...

Keywords: Bhāmatī · Catuḥsūtrī · synopsis · critical · translation · is · evaluation

Abstract

This chapter examines "Bhāmatī (Catuḥsūtrī): A Detailed Synopsis and Critical Evaluation." Bhāmatī (Vācaspati) / Ātmatattvaviveka (Udayana) / Nyāyakusumāñjali (Udayana) / Tattvacintāmaṇi (Gaṅgeśa) / (Maithili translations): detailed synopses and critical evaluations [Translated from the original Sanskrit into Maithili by Gajendra Thakur]. The integrated, extended synopsis and critical evaluation of Gajendra Thakur's translation into literary Maithili considers Bhāmatī, composed by Vācaspati Miśra, the "sarvatantrasvatantra" philosopher of ninth-century Mithila, as a commentary upon Śaṅkarācārya's Śārīraka Bhāṣya and the foundational work of the distinct Bhāmatī school within the history of Advaita Vedānta. For over a thousand years the book remained largely within Sanskrit scholarship, although its author was a son of Mithila.

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Bhāmatī (Catuḥsūtrī)

An Integrated, Extensive Synopsis and Critical Evaluation of Gajendra Thakur's Translation into Literary Maithili

In the Light of Indian and Western Literary Theory

Original Sanskrit: Vācaspati Miśra · Translated from Sanskrit into Maithili: Gajendra Thakur

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From the Adhyāsabhāṣya to the Completion of the Catuḥsūtrī

1. Introduction, Objectives, and Structure of the Work under Review

Bhāmatī, composed by Vācaspati Miśra, the "sarvatantrasvatantra" (independently accomplished in all systems) philosopher of ninth-century Mithila, is a commentary on Śaṅkarācārya's Śārīraka Bhāṣya and the foundational text of a distinct school of Advaita Vedānta, the Bhāmatī tradition. For more than a thousand years, this work remained within the bounds of Sanskrit scholarship, even though its author was himself a son of Mithila. Gajendra Thakur—the editor of the Videha e-journal, a student of the Navya-Nyāya tradition of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, and a literary author active in Maithili, Hindi, Sanskrit, and English—has addressed this

historical absence through a translation directly from the original Sanskrit into literary Maithili. The first edition of 2004 and the expanded, audited and revised edition of 2026 (Videha book series, ISSN 2229-547X) bear witness to the maturation of this translational endeavour over two decades.

The present study has two purposes. The first is to offer a detailed, orderly synopsis of the entire 491-page work under review, omitting no part of the sequence from the auspicious invocations to the final colophon of the Samanvayādhikaraṇa, "Here ends the Catuḥsūtrī-Bhāmatī." The second is to evaluate critically both the original philosophical work and the act of translating it, in the light of Indian poetics—rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, guṇa and rīti, aucitya, and Mithila's own Navya-Nyāya perspective—and Western literary theory: Schleiermacher's and Venuti's concepts of domestication and foreignisation in translation, Nida's dynamic and formal equivalence, Walter Benjamin's "The Task of the Translator," Gadamerian hermeneutics, and the close-reading method of New Criticism.

This research report offers an extensive examination of Vācaspati Miśra's philosophical contribution, the metaphysical doctrines of the Bhāmatī school, the linguistic and philosophical merits of Gajendra Thakur's Maithili translation, and the new intellectual debate made possible by the work's entry into Maithili letters. In addition, it considers at length the institutional contribution to the renaissance of Maithili literature.

The cumulative edition of the translation under review extends from page 1 to page 491 and has the following order: (a) cover and publication pages; (b) the Maithili rendering of Śaṅkara's original Adhyāsabhāṣya; (c) prose translations of Vācaspati Miśra's seven invocatory verses; (d) the complete translation of the Bhāmatī commentary on the Adhyāsabhāṣya, under the heading "Adhyāsa"; (e) the commentary on the first sūtra, "Athāto brahmajijñāsā"; (f) that on the second, "Janmādy asya yataḥ"; (g) that on the third, "Śāstrayonitvāt"; and (h) the extensive commentary on the fourth sūtra, "Tat tu samanvayāt" (the Samanvayādhikaraṇa), which alone occupies approximately a third of the entire book—evidence of the translator's fidelity to the proportions of the Sanskrit Bhāmatī. At the end of the edition, as Chapter Four, stands an extensive bibliography divided into twelve sections. It lists the Maithili edition under review, base texts of the Brahma Sūtras and Śaṅkara's Bhāṣya, Sanskrit editions of Bhāmatī, commentaries and subcommentaries upon it (Vedāntakalpataru, Kalpataruparimala, Ābhoga, Bhāmatītilaka, and others), texts for comparison with the Vivaraṇa school, other works of Vācaspati, modern research, and digital collections; each entry is accompanied by a note on its usefulness. This editorial component is particularly helpful to researchers, although it is not itself part of the act of translation but an auxiliary

resource; for that reason a separate brief account of it is considered sufficient in the present synopsis.

The book is organised into four principal chapters. The first contains the introduction and philosophical examination; the second, a detailed philosophical, translation-critical, and literary assessment; the third, an appendix containing the original translation into literary Maithili; and the fourth, the extensive bibliography. Chapter Three reproduces the entire Catuḥsūtrī-Bhāmatī, beginning with adhyāsa and continuing through the first four Brahma Sūtras.

The second chapter returns to the subjects of the first, but divides them into more finely differentiated subsections: seven on adhyāsa, four on the first sūtra, five on the fourth sūtra, the art of translation, Indian and Western criticism, the book's place in Maithili literature, observations, an epilogue, and an overall judgment.

2. Vācaspati Miśra: The "Sarvatantrasvatantra" Philosopher and His Historical Legacy

Vācaspati Miśra (approximately 900–980 CE) was a figure of extraordinary talent in the history of Indian philosophy. He is said to have been born either in Andharatharhi, in the present Madhubani district of Mithila (described in this account as the capital of King Nṛga at that time), or in the village of Samaul. With the exception of Vaiśeṣika, authoritative commentaries of his are available on almost all the orthodox schools of Indian philosophy, for which learned scholars conferred upon him the designation "sarvatantrasvatantra." The account maintains that there has been no comparable scholar in the Indian philosophical tradition whose writing produced authoritative and epoch-making commentaries across so many of the major branches of the six systems.

Vācaspati Miśra's substantial corpus ranges very widely. In Nyāya, his Nyāyavārttikatātparyaṭīkā brought him renown as "Tātparyācārya" and defended Uddyotakara's Nyāyavārttika. His Nyāyasūcīnibandha is also an important work concerned with the chronological and thematic arrangement of the Nyāya Sūtras. In Sāṃkhya, his Sāṃkhyatattvakaumudī on Īśvarakṛṣṇa's Sāṃkhyakārikā continues to be regarded as a standard exposition. In Yoga, his Tattvavaiśāradī, a commentary on the Vyāsabhāṣya of Patañjali's Yoga Sūtras, elucidates psychological and philosophical difficulties. In Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā, his Nyāyakaṇikā on Maṇḍana Miśra's Vidhiviveka and his independent work on linguistic cognition, Tattvabindu, reveal his Mīmāṃsā standpoint. In Vedānta, his Brahmatattvasamīkṣā on Maṇḍana Miśra's Brahmasiddhi (now unavailable) and Bhāmatī on the Śārīraka Bhāṣya have immortalised his name.

This historical introduction matters because readers should not suppose that Bhāmatī merely explains the individual words and expressions of Śaṅkarācārya. Vācaspati is certainly a follower of the commentator whose work he elucidates, yet his commentary also develops independent arguments, constructs opposing positions, examines the means of knowledge, and classifies concepts. It is this autonomous intellectual character that justifies the designation "Bhāmatī school."

2.1. The Popular Legend Behind the Naming of Bhāmatī

Behind the naming of Bhāmatī, the last and, in this account, greatest work of Vācaspati Miśra's life, stands a deeply affecting and inspirational legend, presented as an enduring emblem of the silent devotion of Indian women. According to popular tradition and the historical references invoked here, Vācaspati married a girl named Bhāmatī while still young. After marriage, he undertook the great project of composing a commentary on Ācārya Śaṅkara's Śārīraka Bhāṣya and requested that his wife not interrupt his scholarly discipline until the work was complete.

Respecting her husband's purpose, Bhāmatī took the entire burden of the household upon herself. For years—about thirty, according to some accounts—Vācaspati remained so absorbed in literary and philosophical study that he did not even notice who was serving him, or who provided his food and water and filled the lamp with oil. One evening, just as the oil in the lamp was running out and the flame was about to die, Vācaspati completed his book. Seeing the fading flame, Bhāmatī came quickly to replenish the oil. When Vācaspati raised his eyes from his manuscript, he saw a mature woman standing before him. Astonished, he asked, "Lady, who are you?" Bhāmatī answered humbly, "My lord, I am your wife, Bhāmatī."

Overwhelmed by his wife's extraordinary sacrifice, limitless dedication, and selfless service, Vācaspati realised that his life-partner had devoted her entire life to his undertaking. To express his gratitude for this immeasurable sacrifice, he named his great Vedānta commentary Bhāmatī, so that the world might remember, for all time, not only philosophical knowledge but also the immense sacrifice of an Indian woman. The work is still counted among the foremost writings of Advaita Vedānta, and Bhāmatī's name remains inscribed in the history of philosophy. In modern times, the author Usha Kiran Khan drew upon this historical-philosophical love story to write the novel Bhāmatī: An Unforgettable Love Story in Maithili and Hindi; the account adds that the work received recognition through a Sahitya Akademi award.

3. The Bhāmatī School, the Vivaraṇa School, and the Commentarial Tradition

The Catuḥsūtrī portion contains the seeds of numerous doctrines of the Bhāmatī school, which the faithful translation brings to light without added external commentary. The philosophical differences between the Bhāmatī school and the Vivaraṇa school, which arose from Prakāśātman Yati's Pañcapādikāvivaraṇa on Padmapādācārya's Pañcapādikā, may be seen in summary in the table below.

The Bhāmatī doctrine that ignorance has the individual self as its locus, the account of realisation of Brahman as a mental modification arising through reflection, and the assimilation of Prābhākara resources into Advaita in the understanding of superimposition as rooted in the non-apprehension of difference—all these points become apparent to the reader within the translated text itself, demonstrating the translator's command of the philosophical tradition.

In the development of Advaita Vedānta after Ācārya Śaṅkara, two major schools emerged: the Bhāmatī school of Vācaspati Miśra and the Vivaraṇa school arising from Prakāśātman Yati's Pañcapādikāvivaraṇa upon Padmapādācārya's Pañcapādikā. Their philosophical differences are essential to understanding the subtleties of Advaita, and Gajendra Thakur's Maithili translation, the review argues, addresses them with complete fidelity.

In the Bhāmatī school, the individual self (jīva) is held to be the agent, the experiencer, and the locus of ignorance. The doctrine that avidyā resides in the jīva is fundamental to Bhāmatī. According to Vācaspati Miśra, ignorance is, in reality, indescribable and can be divided into two aspects: concealment (āvaraṇa, or root ignorance) and projection (vikṣepa, or derivative ignorance/latent impressions). This entire background resonates throughout Gajendra Thakur's translation, in which the translator remains faithful to the text and clarifies Bhāmatī's meaning without inserting extraneous commentary.

The comparison is useful, but a scholarly caution is necessary here. Several propositions distinguishing Bhāmatī from Vivaraṇa are also the result of subsequent generations' systematic classifications. Readers should not therefore assume that all the differences appear as an explicit list in Vācaspati's original text. The work would serve researchers even better if it more sharply distinguished what the original translation says from what the later history of doctrines attributes to the tradition.

Bhāmatī is so mature and demanding a work that it has itself generated a considerable literature of commentaries. In the thirteenth century, Amalānanda Sarasvatī, whose teacher was Anubhavānanda, wrote the

celebrated Vedāntakalpataru upon Bhāmatī, bringing new distinction to the Bhāmatī school within Advaita Vedānta. In the sixteenth century, Appayya Dīkṣita wrote the Kalpataruparimala on Amalānanda's Kalpataru, and Lakṣmīnṛsiṃha composed the Ābhoga. Other commentaries on Bhāmatī include Vallālasūri's Bhāmatītilaka, Akhaṇḍānubhūti Yati's Ṛjuprakāśikā, Acyutakṛṣṇatīrtha's Bhāmatībhāvadīpikā, and Subrahmaṇya Śāstrī's Bhāmatīvivaraṇa.

In places, subtle doctrinal differences become visible between Bhāmatī and Kalpataru. Where Appayya Dīkṣita, in the Parimala, found Vācaspati and Amalānanda at variance with the Śārīraka Bhāṣya, he refuted their positions and upheld the Bhāṣya. The author of the Ābhoga, Lakṣmīnṛsiṃha, strongly criticised this procedure in the Parimala and defended the authors of Bhāmatī and Kalpataru. Thus two subsidiary interpretive tendencies also developed within the Bhāmatī school itself. This entire commentarial inheritance testifies to the enduring intellectual authority of Vācaspati Miśra's original work.

Philosophical and epistemological question	Bhāmatī school (Vācaspati Miśra)	Vivaraṇa school (Padmapāda / Prakāśātman)
Locus of ignorance (avidyā)	The locus of avidyā is the individual self (jīva): ignorance resides in the jīva. Brahman is its object, not its locus.	The locus of avidyā is Brahman: ignorance is situated in Brahman.
Nature of jīva and Īśvara	Avacchedavāda: the individual self is Brahman delimited by ignorance, as pot-space is delimited relative to infinite space.	Pratibimbavāda: the individual self is the reflection of Brahman in ignorance, as the sun is reflected in water.
Unity or plurality of ignorance	Ignorance is multiple: many individual selves, many forms of ignorance. Each self has its own avidyā.	Root ignorance (mūlāvidyā) is one. The whole phenomenal world is the effect of a single ignorance.
Means to the realisation of Brahman	The mental modification assuming the form of Brahman, arising through reflection (manana), is the principal means of immediate knowledge (with nididhyāsana).	The great Upaniṣadic sentence (mahāvākya), as verbal testimony, directly produces immediate knowledge (śabdāparokṣavāda / śravaṇa).
Means of liberation	The jīva is the locus of ignorance and attains liberation while living through nididhyāsana.	Hearing alone is sufficient; ignorance resides in Brahman and is automatically destroyed by the knowledge of Brahman.
Creation and the mixing of elements	Trivṛtkaraṇa: the blending of three elements—fire, water, and food/earth—is accepted.	Pañcīkaraṇa: the blending of five elements—ether, air, fire, water, and earth—is accepted.

4. Extended Synopsis and Philosophical Examination

4.1. The Auspicious Invocation: A Meeting of Philosophy and Poetry

The seven auspicious verses of Bhāmatī are rendered in prose rather than metrical translation, giving priority to the preservation of meaning over

the preservation of metre. In the first verse, Brahman is saluted as "the very nature of immeasurable bliss and knowledge" and as the source of the illusory manifestation of the five elements, "having made the two kinds of indescribable ignorance his ministers." Here, already, one encounters the seed of the Bhāmatī school's teaching concerning two aspects of ignorance: concealment and projection or latent impression. The second verse declares, "The Vedas are his breath, the five great elements his sight, the moving and unmoving world his smile, and his sleep the great dissolution." The Maithili word muskī, "smile," lends the cosmic play an intimate domestic warmth. Invocations of Veda-bhava, Mārtaṇḍa-Tilakasvāmin-Mahāgaṇapati, Vyāsa, and Śaṅkara follow in sequence. The humility expressed by the seventh verse—"Just as water from the royal road becomes pure upon entering the current of the Ganges, so the insignificant words of one such as myself are sanctified when joined to the ācārya's composition"—embodies the commentator's traditional intellectual modesty.

The translator's method is already clear in these invocations: metre may be relinquished, but not meaning; Sanskrit terminology may be retained, but the sentence must breathe in Maithili. Throughout the translation, this policy repeatedly proves successful.

4.2. The Adhyāsabhāṣya: The Opponent's Position, Figurative and Erroneous Usage, Theories of Illusion, and the Self-Luminosity of the Ātman

The commentary opens with an extended pūrvapakṣa, or prima facie objection: something about which there is no doubt, and knowledge of which serves no purpose, cannot be an object of inquiry. The illustrations are "a pot present in brilliant light" and "a crow's teeth." The opponent maintains that the immediate experience of "I" (asmat) is beyond dispute in all beings, from insects to gods and seers. Through arguments concerning recognition of the same self from childhood to old age, flowers and the thread upon which they are strung, the sublation of a divine dream-body, identity of the self despite a tiger's body brought about by yogic power, and the variability of the senses, the self is distinguished from the body, senses, and related faculties. The opponent's culminating assertion—"Even a thousand scriptures together cannot turn a pot into cloth"—supports the insistence that scriptural statements apparently contrary to experience must be understood figuratively.

The siddhānta, or established position, uses indicators of textual purport—including opening and conclusion, repetition, and others—to show that scripture teaches the self free of limiting adjuncts. Knowledge arising from scripture does not abolish the practical validity of perception; it denies only the latter's claim to ultimate validity. This distinction between the

empirical (vyāvahārika) and ultimate (pāramārthika) levels is fundamental to Advaita epistemology. Illustrations such as the figurative expression "Dīrghā is shrieking," the Agnihotra of the Kuṇḍapāyins' sacrificial course, the lion-like disciple, and the mustard-seed/oil example demonstrate that figurative predication presupposes awareness of a difference. In the use of "I" with reference to the body, however, such discriminating knowledge is absent; the usage is therefore not merely figurative but false, an instance of superimposition (adhyāsa).

The commentary's definition of superimposition—"the manifestation, elsewhere, of something previously perceived, in a form resembling memory"—is analysed word by word and tested for overextension and underextension, with examples such as recognition of cowhood in the cow Kālākṣī and dream cognition. The entire ordinary repertory of illusion is translated: silver in a shell, mistaken identification in a mirror's reflection, two moons, the circle of a whirling firebrand, a mirage, and a snake perceived in bamboo. Against this background the classical dispute over theories of erroneous appearance (khyātivāda) unfolds: ātmakhyāti among Sautrāntika and Vijñānavādin Buddhists, akhyāti among Prābhākara Mīmāṃsakas, and anyathākhyāti among the Naiyāyikas. Vācaspati sharply criticises these positions, sometimes with the force of sarcasm: "Ah! What extraordinary good fortune belongs to this poor cognition, that it can acquire certainty even through falsehood!" The established doctrine is anirvacanīyakhyāti: the mirage-water superimposed upon rays is neither real nor unreal, nor both real and unreal. This threefold refusal, which locates illusion as distinct from both existence and non-existence (sad-asad-vilakṣaṇa), lies at the heart of Advaita epistemology.

The debate over the self-luminosity of consciousness employs the objection of a blind man led by another blind man, both stumbling at every step (the defect of a blind succession), the infinite regress resulting from postulating a further cognition to know each cognition, and a refutation of the Vijñānavādin claim that consciousness reveals its object. These arguments establish the self as self-luminous, eternal, and without parts. The illustration of a foolish child attributing stains to the imperceptible sky—imagined as a vast inverted bowl made of sapphire—shows how the sense of individual selfhood arises through the mind, intellect, and bodily limiting adjuncts projected by ignorance.

> "The learned call superimposition ignorance": this paired characterisation, the dependence of the status of knower upon superimposition, and the famous analogy with animal behaviour—fleeing at the sight of a man raising a stick, approaching at the sight of green grass—become vivid pictures of village life in Maithili. With the distinction between superimposition of properties (dharmādhyāsa: "I am mute / one-eyed / deaf") and superimposition upon the substratum

(dharmyadhyāsa, discussed through desire, intention, doubt, and conviction), the introduction concludes with the commitment to eradicate the latent dispositions of illusion through the practice of true knowledge.

Ātmakhyāti (Buddhist Sautrāntika / Vijñānavāda): the external object is treated as non-existent and the internally constituted form of cognition is projected outward.

Akhyāti (Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā): failure to discriminate between memory and present apprehension; memory loses its recognisable character as memory.

Anyathākhyāti (Nyāya): the cognition of one existent object as another—for example, the appearance in a shell of silver existing in the marketplace.

This section also matters in the language of modern philosophy, because its question is not merely "Why does error occur?" but "What is the ontological status of the object present in experience?" The translation preserves the philosophical gravity of that question.

4.3. The First Sūtra, "Athāto brahmajijñāsā": Qualification, Means, the Relation Between Action and Knowledge, and Liberation

The central concerns of the first sūtra are the examination of four possible meanings of atha—sequence, beginning, auspiciousness, and qualification—and the rejection of the view that inquiry into Brahman must follow inquiry into dharma. Brahman-realisation is excluded from all four categories of things accomplished by action: something produced, transformed, purified, or obtained. Four examples illustrate these types: a ball of dough, curd, the ritual sprinkling of a mortar, and the milking of a cow. Ritual action is assigned only the status of a "remote auxiliary." The explanation of the four prerequisites—discrimination between the eternal and the non-eternal, dispassion toward enjoyments here and hereafter, the discipline comprising tranquillity and self-control, and the desire for liberation—makes enlivening use of illustrations concerning fish with bones, rice with husks, and the farmer who does not abandon his seed through fear of wild animals. At the close, the interpretation of "brahmaṇe jijñāsā" as a dative compound is rejected in favour of "brahmaṇaḥ jijñāsā" as a genitive tatpuruṣa compound. This is historically significant because Vācaspati here contests a tradition of glossators prior to Śaṅkara. The discussion ends with a historical survey of theories of the self: Lokāyata materialism, the view that the senses themselves constitute the self, mind-as-self theory, momentary consciousness theory, nihilism, Sāṃkhya, the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika doctrine of a God distinct from the individual self, and Advaita—a miniature encyclopaedia of Indian philosophy.

The meanings "auspiciousness," "beginning," and "qualification" are set aside in favour of "sequence." Examples of auspicious sound are the beating of a mṛdaṅga drum or the sounding of a conch, and the sight of a water-filled pitcher brought for another purpose. The Mīmāṃsā opponent's contention that inquiry into Brahman should come after inquiry into dharma is decisively rejected. Liberation is neither produced (like a ball of dough), transformed (like curd), purified (like a mortar ritually sprinkled with water), nor acquired (like milk obtained by milking). Action is only a "remote auxiliary" of detachment and purification of the intellect.

The real strength of this sūtra lies in its examination of the relation between ritual action and knowledge. The Pūrva-Mīmāṃsā requirement that inquiry into Brahman must follow inquiry into dharma is rejected as a strict necessity. Yet action is not declared wholly meaningless. The book preserves different views in the original text: action removes impurities from the internal organ; purifies the seeker; discharges the three debts; or assists contemplation of Brahman. Within this discussion there emerges the sequence of hearing (śravaṇa), reflection (manana), and sustained meditation (nididhyāsana).

Here the translator's particular achievement is that ordinary examples prevent readers from becoming exhausted by exceptionally technical Mīmāṃsā argument. Fish with bones, rice with husks, the fear of wild beasts, the fear of a beggar, and poison mixed with honey are not decorative details in the argument for renunciation: they become examples bearing philosophical evidential force.

Bhāmatī's discipline of knowledge is especially subtle here. The meaning of scriptural statements received through hearing is strengthened by reflection; sustained meditation removes contrary dispositions; and the mental modification assuming the form of Brahman reveals the true "tat" (That) underlying the "tvam" (thou) bound by limiting adjuncts. Liberation is not produced: ignorance is removed.

4.4. The Second Sūtra, "Janmādy asya yataḥ": Brahman as the Cause of the World

The central argument of this sūtra establishes an extrinsic or indicative definition (taṭasthalakṣaṇa): "Because the world arises from Brahman, the world can serve as a distinguishing mark of Brahman, just as the sun's movement is indicated by its arrival in different places." It discusses Yāska's six modifications of being—birth, existence, growth, transformation, decline, and destruction—and their inclusion under origination, continuance, and dissolution. From the diversity of the world it argues for an omniscient and omnipotent cause, with four striking examples of natural regularity, including the blackbuck's appearance in a particular region, the cuckoo's calling at a particular season, and the conception of a

crane following thunder at the beginning of the rains. The decisive turn in the argument is that the sūtra does not indicate an independent inference; rather, it restates the Taittirīya Upaniṣad's dialogue between Bhṛgu and Varuṇa. The example of a rope, together with ignorance, acting as the material basis of an imagined snake establishes Brahman, together with ignorance, as the material cause. The distinction between cognition governed by its object (vastutantra) and cognition or practice governed by the person (puruṣatantra) is also introduced here, preparing for the fourth sūtra.

Brahman is not only the efficient cause (nimittakāraṇa); Brahman together with ignorance is also the material cause (upādānakāraṇa). The rope-and-snake illustration gives this difficult Advaita theory of causation a compact, visible form.

4.5. The Third Sūtra, "Śāstrayonitvāt": The Twofold Relation Between Brahman and Scripture

Two interpretations authorised by the tradition are offered in sequence. (a) "Brahman is the cause of scripture": Brahman is the source of the entire body of scriptures comprising countless branches of knowledge; the example of Pāṇini's grammar establishes the concomitance that "the creator of a science possesses knowledge broader than the subject matter of that science." (b) "Scripture is the means of knowing Brahman": Brahman is known through scripture alone, not through an independent inference. The discussion of the eternality of the Veda is particularly valuable here. Mīmāṃsakas who hold phonemes to be eternal are obliged to acknowledge that sequences of words and sentences arranged in a particular order are not eternal in the same sense; the example of a dance teacher and pupil explains the transmission of a fixed Vedic recitation sequence; and the positions of Jaimini and Vyāsa are reconciled. "In no creation does Brahmin-killing become meritorious, nor does the horse sacrifice become sinful; just as fire never wets and water never burns." This subtle account of things having fixed natures makes the analysis of Vedic authority available in Maithili at an unprecedented level of depth.

4.6. The Fourth Sūtra, "Tat tu samanvayāt": The Efficacy of Vedāntic Statements, Object-Governed Knowledge, the Eternity of Liberation, and Liberation While Living

The Samanvayādhikaraṇa is the largest and most densely argumentative portion of the book, occupying approximately a third of the whole translation. Its opposing position rests on a Mīmāṃsā principle: "The purpose of scripture is to teach action." Statements of Vedānta must accordingly be regarded either as subsidiary to injunctions, as prescribing acts such as meditation, or as prescribing worship of Brahman to those desiring immortality—the doctrine of an injunction to apprehend

(pratipattividhi-vāda). The objection from experience that "Even after hearing tat tvam asi, the conditions of worldly existence—pleasure, pain, fear, and so forth—remain as before" is also part of the pūrvapakṣa. The established position vindicates the fundamental claim that "all Vedāntic sentences converge upon Brahman with a single purport," appealing to scriptural statements such as "Sad eva somya idam agra āsīt" and "Ekam eva advitīyam," and to the unity of purport between a text's beginning and its conclusion.

The successive rejection of all four forms of a product of action—something produced, transformed, purified, or acquired—is the backbone of this section's demonstration that liberation is eternal. The appealing image of a boatman and boat moving away from changing banks, foam, and waves toward the still, wave-free middle; the impossibility of imparting an additional quality to Brahman (as one colours a hibiscus with lac-dye); and the impossibility of removing a defect from Brahman (as one polishes a mirror with brick powder) support the conclusion that "Not even the shadow of action, apart from knowledge, can enter into liberation." This is accompanied by the distinction between immutable eternality (kūṭastha-nityatā) and the eternality of something that undergoes change (pariṇāmi-nityatā); an extended refutation of doctrines of difference-and-non-difference ("One does not say of a pot that there is a jujube in it; nor, even when Caitra and Maitra sit on the same seat, does one say that Caitra is Maitra"); and the teaching "Clay alone is real" (vācārambhaṇa), which establishes the immutable standpoint. The discussion also includes the body of scriptural passages that appear to describe liberation as having a beginning and end, and Vāmadeva's declaration, "I became Manu; I became the Sun."

The Bhāṣya's teaching that "Knowledge is governed by the object (vastutantra), not by the person (puruṣatantra)" is explained through the contrast between superimpositional meditation—"The mind is indeed fire"—which depends on a person's volition, and the cognition that actual fire is fire, which depends on the object. Two unforgettable passages of Bhāmatī demonstrate that propositions concerning already existent things are efficacious: ornate prose describing Mount Sumeru, and the celebrated story of a Dravidian who did not know the language of the Āryas. When a messenger declares "A son has been born to you," the Dravidian infers the sentence's meaning from the gooseflesh and delighted face of Devadatta. This epoch-making argument in philosophy of language flows like a story in Maithili. There is also a subtle analysis of negation ("One should not kill a Brahmin": the negative particle as expressing absence, and the interpretation of exclusion or paryudāsa in the Prajāpati vow). Finally the distinction between figurative and erroneous identification with the ego, and the establishment of liberation while living—illustrated by the scriptural image of a snake's discarded skin lying lifeless upon its anthill—

complete the book's argumentative circle. The final proposition is: "With the knowledge 'I am Brahman', all injunctions and every other means of knowledge come to an end." By reconnecting its conclusion to the first sūtra, in a form of circular or ring composition, this translation of the Catuḥsūtrī-Bhāmatī concludes.

Statements about an already established reality are not meaningless. Merely hearing "This is a rope, not a snake" may dispel fear caused by an illusion. Similarly, knowledge of Brahman is efficacious in itself once the self's apparent involvement in worldly existence is recognised as false. Hearing, reflection, and sustained meditation do not produce a new liberation; they remove doubt and contrary mental impressions.

Examples involving a pot and a jujube fruit, Caitra and Maitra, and gold and an earring show the difficulty of treating difference and non-difference as equally real within one relation. Knowing from a distance that something is gold does not yield knowledge of that particular object as an earring. This gives rise to the distinction between general knowledge of a substance and knowledge of a specific form. If difference and non-difference mutually depend on one another, the defect of reciprocal dependence arises.

The subtle investigation of the meaning of "not," paryudāsa, prohibition, and cessation belongs to the most demanding passages in the book's philosophy of language. Examples such as the fact that removing armour does not immediately end life if no arrow strikes explain cessation and its relation to a result. Finally, in distinguishing figurative from erroneous ego-identification and discussing liberation while alive, the text employs the examples of a snake's abandoned slough and a person who has given up wealth. The practical purpose of injunction and other instruments of knowledge coming to an end with the cognition "I am Brahman" constitutes the culmination of the Catuḥsūtrī.

5. Translation Theory, Linguistic Strategy, Idiom, and the Formation of Philosophical Terminology

The translator's linguistic strategy works on three levels. First is terminological precision: words such as adhyāsa, anirvacanīya, samānādhikaraṇa, pratyabhijñā, arthāpatti, saṃyoga-pṛthaktva, kūṭastha, and upādāna are retained, but explained in Maithili at their first occurrence. This allows a successful and durable philosophical vocabulary for Mīmāṃsā, Nyāya, and Vedānta to emerge in Maithili. Second is the Maithilisation of sentence structure: long Sanskrit constructions made up of elaborate compounds are broken into sentences introduced by formulations such as "The point is—", "Suppose that", "What is being said is—", and "The response given is...". These guideposts make the movement and pauses of debate clear. Third is the judicious use of

indigenous idiom—"The blind man holds the hand of another blind man and falls at every step"; "Barley pudding is not salty"; "Not even a thousand scriptures together can turn a pot into cloth." This transformation of Sanskrit maxims into Maithili popular speech is the translation's finest achievement. Agreement in gender and number, disciplined use of chathi (the honorific form for Brahman, the self, or an ācārya) and achi (the ordinary form), and consistent use of the dotted retroflex letters (ṛ/ṭh corresponding to ड़/ढ़, in accordance with the Videha standard) are maintained throughout the 491 pages, attesting to the editorial labour behind the edition.

Gajendra Thakur's translation follows the principle of being "faithful to meaning but free in verbal expression." It does not deviate in the slightest from the original sequence of arguments, examples, and evidentiary authorities, but its syntax belongs entirely to Maithili's indigenous character.

"Even a thousand craftsmen cannot make cloth out of a pot."

"Inquiry into a useless matter is like examining the teeth of an arrow."

Throughout the review, it should remain clear that, however important the first and second chapters may be, the book's lasting value rests on the actual translated text in its third chapter. That appendix presents, in sequence, adhyāsa and the Catuḥsūtrī-Bhāmatī on Brahma Sūtras 1.1.1–1.1.4.

The chief merit of the translation is that the sequence of reasoning never breaks. However extended the opponent's argument, it has not been artificially shortened. Examples, objections, replies, renewed objections, sūtras, statements of the Bhāṣya, grammatical analyses, and Mīmāṃsā maxims have all been retained. The reader therefore sees not merely "what conclusion Vācaspati reached," but also "how he reached it."

Writing philosophical Maithili presents two dangers: on the one hand, so much Sanskrit weight that Maithili becomes little more than a language of case endings; on the other, so much simplification that distinctions essential to the śāstras disappear. The best passages of this translation avoid both dangers.

A particular achievement is that indigenous expression does not turn into humour or rusticity for its own sake; the dignity of serious philosophical prose remains intact. An expression such as "The blind man holds the hand of another blind man…" communicates the problem of infinite regress more immediately than many Sanskritic definitions.

This translation cannot be classified under either of the two commonplace labels "literal" or "free." Its method is fundamentally a meaning-oriented translation faithful to argument. The source's philosophical progression, opposing positions, examples, and authorities are retained; its Sanskrit

sentence construction is not. Thus the translation is faithful to the philosophical architecture of its source without sounding artificial in Maithili.

The temptation to replace every technical term with a wholly indigenous synonym has been resisted. If adhyāsa were translated simply as "superimposition" on every occasion, the conceptual history of the term would be effaced; the same applies to anirvacanīya, pratyabhijñā, kūṭastha, and upādāna. The surrounding Maithili sentence nevertheless unfolds their meanings. Rather than minting wholly new technical terms, the procedure accepts established terms and explains them through Maithili syntax. In practice this approach works well for translating philosophy.

6. A Critical Evaluation in the Light of Indian Literary Theory

6.1. Rasa Theory: The Undercurrent of Śānta Rasa in Philosophical Debate

The rasa theory associated with Bharata, Ānandavardhana, and Abhinavagupta was originally developed for poetry and drama; nevertheless, its use in philosophical prose is not inappropriate, particularly when the subject itself concerns liberation and the stilling of mental activity. In this translation, the supporting determinant (ālambana-vibhāva) is attributeless Brahman, the exciting determinant (uddīpana-vibhāva) is the dialectical movement between objection and established conclusion, and the transitory feelings (vyabhicāri-bhāvas) include intellectual curiosity, wonder, and flashes of humour in Vācaspati's irony. The overarching abiding emotion is śama, tranquillity, the basis of śānta rasa, which reaches fruition in the final description of liberation while living in the Samanvayādhikaraṇa. The translator does not disturb this aesthetic undercurrent; instead the flavour of Maithili idioms—"Barley pudding is not salty"; "Even a thousand scriptures cannot turn a pot into cloth"—irrigates the dryness of debate with liveliness, approaching the quality of mādhurya, sweetness, in Indian poetics.

6.2. Dhvani Theory: The Power of Suggestion in Fidelity to the Text

According to Ānandavardhana's dhvani theory, the soul of poetry lies in suggested meaning (vyaṅgyārtha) beyond literal meaning (vācyārtha). The translator inserts no explanatory commentary at any point: the distinctive doctrines of the Bhāmatī school—ignorance having the individual self as its locus, and realisation arising through reflection—are suggested to the reader through a faithful translation alone. This ideal of the "translator's invisibility," also considered important in Western translation theory (see 6.1), accords with the dual categories of vastu-dhvani and rasa-dhvani in

Indian theories of suggestion: while the literal sense of Vācaspati's argument remains, the philosophical intent it suggests emerges spontaneously in the mind of the Maithili reader.

6.3. Vakrokti: Vācaspati's Irony and Its Preservation in Translation

Kuntaka's theory of vakrokti regards "a skilfully inflected expression of word and meaning" (śabdārthayoḥ vaidagdhyabhaṅgībhaṇiti) as the basis of the poetic. Vācaspati's debates make extensive use of figurative obliqueness, as in the sarcastic compliment directed at Nyāya—"Ah! What extraordinary good fortune this poor cognition enjoys, that it attains certainty even by means of falsehood!"—and of sentence-level obliqueness in the handling of objection and reply through an elaborated mode of disputation. Gajendra Thakur's translation brings this art of irony into harmony with Maithili's own capacities for satire, abundant in its traditions of idiom and jest. This demonstrates the translator's sensitivity to vakrokti in both languages.

6.4. Guṇa and Rīti: Prasāda, Mādhurya, and Samatā

Viewed through Vāmana's theory of rīti and the discussions of poetic qualities by Daṇḍin and Bhāmaha, this translation exemplifies prasāda: clarity and ease of expression even in the presence of profound meaning, allowing the most difficult disputation to enter the reader's mind without obstruction. Samatā, the evenness of classical prose—a consistent manner of composition free from display or slackness—is a lasting characteristic of the work. Indigenous expressions such as ijot (light), anhār (darkness), muskī (smile), bāchā (calf), auṅṭhī (ring), keńchulī (slough), bāḅī (anthill), dhuṅdhalakā (dimness), gaṛeriyā (shepherd), bhūśī (husk), okhalī (mortar), julāhā (weaver), and kumhār (potter) convey mādhurya—the quality of sweetness or emotional softness—without allowing excessive rusticity to destroy intellectual seriousness. The result is a delicate balance akin to Bharata's intelligibility of meaning and Daṇḍin's unencumbered clarity.

6.5. Aucitya: Judged by Kṣemendra's Standard

In Kṣemendra's Aucityavicāracarcā, appropriateness of rasa, sense, figure, and expression determines the grace of poetry and, by extension, classical prose. Three decisions of appropriateness are especially notable in this translation: (a) rendering the verses in prose, since precision of philosophical meaning takes precedence over metrical constraint; (b) retaining technical terms—adhyāsa, anirvacanīya, samānādhikaraṇa, pratyabhijñā, kūṭastha, and upādāna—as essential to preserving delicate doctrinal distinctions; and (c) employing vernacular maxims sparingly but accurately, since excess would impair scholarly dignity. All three decisions meet the demands of appropriateness at the levels of sentence, word, and sound.

6.6. Terminological Precision from the Perspective of Navya-Nyāya

From the standpoint of Mithila's own Navya-Nyāya tradition—the Tattvacintāmaṇi lineage of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, with antecedents in Bhāmatī's discussions of erroneous cognition and epistemic validity—the translation deserves particular praise. It preserves the method of testing definitions for overextension, underextension, and impossibility; the strict sequence of reason, probandum, and invariable concomitance; and the disciplined movement of each argument through opponent's thesis, objection, resolution, renewed objection, and established conclusion. Navya-Nyāya's art of constructing definitions, in which every word performs a necessary task and none is superfluous or missing, is reflected in the Maithili syntax. Each transition formula—"The point is—", "Suppose", "What is being said is—"—appears precisely where a logical connection is required, neither more nor less.

7. Evaluation in the Light of Western Literary and Translation Theory

7.1. Foreignisation and Domestication

Applied to this translation, Friedrich Schleiermacher's celebrated distinction of 1813—"Either the translator brings the reader toward the author (foreignising), or brings the author toward the reader (domesticating)"—reveals a subtle hybridity. At the levels of logical structure, order of examples, sequence of evidential authorities, and terminology, the translation is entirely source-faithful and foreignising. In Lawrence Venuti's terms, it "keeps the foreignness of the original visible in the target language," enabling the work to stand as a philosophical text in its own right, not merely as a simplified digest. In its manner of expression, however—syntax, idiom, and cadence—it is thoroughly domesticating, making rich use of Maithili idiom and indigenous vocabulary. The simultaneous presence of these two tendencies without mutual contradiction is arguably the translation's greatest theoretical accomplishment. It shows that foreignisation and domestication need not be incompatible: they may operate together on different levels, content on the one hand and style on the other.

7.2. Nida's Formal and Dynamic Equivalence

Measured against Eugene Nida's distinction between formal equivalence (preserving the structure of the source as far as possible) and dynamic equivalence (creating in the reader of the target language an effect comparable to that of the source), the translation is distinctive in realising both together, where Nida's formulation often presents them as alternatives. The unwavering preservation of argumentative and evidentiary order enacts formal equivalence. Maithilising sentence

structure—breaking elaborate Sanskrit compounds into short, conversational sentences—enacts dynamic equivalence, so that a modern Maithili reader experiences the kind of intellectual effect that the Sanskrit original produced upon a reader trained in Sanskrit.

7.3. Gadamer's "Fusion of Horizons" and Benjamin's "The Task of the Translator"

In Hans-Georg Gadamer's hermeneutics, understanding is always a "fusion of horizons": the historical and cultural horizons of reader and text come together to generate new meaning. Bhāmatī operates at a doubled, indeed three-layered hermeneutic level: Śaṅkara's Adhyāsabhāṣya as source text; Vācaspati Miśra's commentary as a ninth-century horizon of interpretation; and Gajendra Thakur's Maithili translation as the third, twenty-first-century horizon. The clear distinction between quotations from the Bhāṣya and the prose of the commentary makes this triple hermeneutic structure transparent. It also accords with Walter Benjamin's argument in "The Task of the Translator": translation should not replace the original, but reveal both original and target language as complementary fragments of a "pure language" (reine Sprache). Here, Maithili becomes a vehicle of the "pure language" of Sanskrit argument rather than its rival.

7.4. Reader-Response Theory

From the standpoint of Wolfgang Iser's and Stanley Fish's reader-response theories, this translation makes the reader an active participant not simply in a conclusion but in the whole process of disputation: opposing thesis, question, answer, renewed question, resolution, and established doctrine. Guiding expressions such as "Suppose" (māno, a translation of Sanskrit nanu) repeatedly invite the reader to assume the opponent's position, thus becoming a participant in filling the textual "gaps" described by Iser. This technique transforms the prose of philosophical controversy from dry informational exposition into a dynamic, almost dramatic intellectual experience.

7.5. New Criticism: Close Reading and Organic Unity

Judged by New Criticism's standards of "close reading" and "organic unity," the translation's internal coherence is particularly noteworthy. The consistent use of technical terms such as aparokṣa, bhedāgraha, and gauṇa-mithyā, established at the outset in the Adhyāsabhāṣya section and sustained through the fourth sūtra, makes the text an organic, self-sufficient whole. The relation between its parts and the complete work accords with the ideal of Cleanth Brooks's "well-wrought urn." From the standpoint of composition, the final sentence's return to the first sūtra is a clear example of ring composition or structural closure, a quality admired by the New Critics.

7.6. The Question of Limits in Comparative Theory

The book assesses the translation through the Indian poetic qualities of prasāda and samatā, along with vakrokti and aucitya. Its discussion of Vācaspati's ironic sentences, the preservation of classical technical vocabulary, and the appropriate placement of indigenous idioms is particularly meaningful. From the standpoint of Western translation thought, it identifies the balance between fidelity to the source and fidelity to the target language, and the hermeneutic challenge presented by the two levels of Bhāṣya and commentary.

The limitation of this critical portion is that it names and describes Western theories but does not undertake an extended comparative dialogue between them and the original text. It is therefore better described as a series of "theoretical indications" than as an independent treatise in comparative theory. Given the book's purpose, this limitation is not fatal.

8. Maithili Letters, Videha, and the Institutional Landscape

> "Vācaspati Miśra was a Maithil": this statement of pride has been repeated often in Maithili, but his works were not available in the language. Gajendra Thakur's translation fills that historical gap and converts cultural pride into a body of texts that can be studied. In the bridge being built from classical Sanskrit works into Maithili through the Videha e-journal (founded in 2000, ISSN 2229-547X) and its book series, the inclusion of so formidable a philosophical work as Bhāmatī demonstrates that Maithili can convey not only songs and stories but also the most rigorous scholarly argument.

Gajendra Thakur has also published a Maithili translation of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi, which this account describes as a supreme work of Nyāya philosophy and a revolutionary step towards restoring Mithila's philosophical inheritance. His contribution to literature is presented as no less remarkable. His extensive Maithili novel Gohi Sabhak Beech Jalsamadhi (A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles) is described as an unusual combination of Nyāya philosophy and a contemporary crime narrative, revealing social and philosophical reality through the metaphor "The crocodile eats the body, not the name."

National institutions such as the Sahitya Akademi have also played an important part in this renaissance of Maithili literature. After Maithili was included in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution by the Ninety-second Constitutional Amendment of 2003, Maithili literature received wider national recognition. The Sahitya Akademi continues to honour outstanding writing in Maithili. According to the account in the book, the Sahitya Akademi Award for 2025 was given to the senior author Dr Mahendra Jha for his memoir Dhātrī Pāt San Gām, presented as a vivid

record of rural life, social organisation, and human feeling. Earlier awards mentioned here include Yashodhar Jha's Mithilā Vaibhav (philosophical essays) in 1966 and Yatri (Nagarjun)'s Patrahīn Nagna Gāch in 1968.

The contribution of institutions such as the National Library, Kolkata, and the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA) to the preservation of Maithili philosophical and literary texts also merits remembrance. The National Library originated in the nineteenth century as the Calcutta Public Library and is described here as India's largest library, preserving more than 2.2 million books and manuscripts. The account states that its Maithili holdings preserve rare and ancient manuscripts including Vidyāpati's Kīrtilatā, Kīrtipatākā, and Puruṣaparīkṣā and Jyotirīśvara Ṭhākura's Varṇaratnākara, indispensable for studying Maithili's early and medieval history. Institutions such as IGNCA and the Asiatic Society are digitising thousands of manuscripts, including philosophical and Tantric works written in the Maithili (Tirhuta) script. These institutional and individual efforts continue to widen the language's intellectual horizon.

There is substance in this argument, since Vācaspati Miśra is a central figure in Mithila's philosophical history. Bringing his work to Maithili readers is not merely a translation; it is a kind of restoration of intellectual history.

9. The Academic Value of the Extensive Bibliography

Chapter Four is not merely a list of names. Each section also explains the usefulness of the works it contains. The material is arranged in sequence: the Maithili edition under review; base texts of the Brahma Sūtras and Śaṅkara's Bhāṣya; Sanskrit editions of Bhāmatī; translations focused on the Catuḥsūtrī; commentaries and subcommentaries; the Vivaraṇa school; other works by Vācaspati; modern studies; histories, methods, and epistemology of Advaita; the Upaniṣads and the Prasthānatrayī; digital collections; and rare or uncertain works.

The bibliography includes Bālaśāstrī's Bibliotheca Indica edition, Jīvānanda Vidyāsāgara's edition, Dhuṇḍhirāja Śāstrī's Kāśī edition, and composite editions containing the Bhāṣya, Bhāmatī, Kalpataru, and Parimala, among others.

The modern scholarship is equally extensive, including Hasurkar, Sahadeva Jha, Rajendra Prasad Dubey, Ranganatha, Rudurmūn, Karl Potter, Hajime Nakamura, Michael Comans, Eliot Deutsch, Anantanand Rambachan, Bina Gupta, and Andrew Fort.

Especially commendable is the caution "full verification required" attached to rare works. For Ābhoga, Ṛjuprakāśikā, Bhāmatībhāvadīpikā, Bhāmatīvivaraṇa, Vedāntakalpatarumañjarī, Bhāmatīvyākhyā,

Bhāmatīvilāsa, and other texts, the book does not feign certainty. Instead, it advises verification against manuscript catalogues and institutional records.

Researchers are given useful methodological directions: follow the progression sūtra → Śaṅkara's Bhāṣya → Bhāmatī → Kalpataru → Parimala; specify editions and pages; collate textual variants; compare translations while treating the Sanskrit original as decisive; and never rely upon OCR-extracted text as the sole basis for a direct quotation.

10. The English Latter Half of the Book and Its Bilingual Structure

One important structural feature of this file must be identified: after the Maithili portion ends, the book starts again in English with publication pages, contents, Chapter One, Chapter Two, the complete text concerning the Catuḥsūtrī, and a bibliography. The English contents display the same four-part structure: philosophical study, extensive criticism, an English presentation of the appendix entitled "Pure Maithili Translation of Bhamati," and an extensive bibliography.

The English portion again presents the Bhāmatī–Vivaraṇa comparative table, discussions of adhyāsa, theories of erroneous cognition, inquiry into Brahman, and the Samanvayādhikaraṇa in full. Its concluding English bibliography also repeats modern studies of Bhāmatī and sources in Advaita Vedānta.

This bilingual arrangement has advantages: it makes the material accessible to scholars who do not read Maithili. Nevertheless, there is an editorial problem. The book's principal description presents it as a "translation from Sanskrit into literary Maithili," whereas a substantial latter portion of the file is in English. A future edition would make the actual bilingual structure immediately intelligible by announcing on the cover or publication pages something like "Maithili translation of the original, with an English study and rendering."

There is a second matter. The first two critical chapters in the Maithili and English portions repeat nearly the same structure. This is useful for research but increases the length of a printed 6 × 9-inch hardback. If bilingual presentation is an explicit publishing aim, the arrangement is appropriate; if the main aim is an edition wholly in Maithili, it would be more natural to make the English portion a separate companion volume or edition.

11. Editorial and Textual Refinements

The spelling aparokkṣa occurs seven times in the text, whereas the correct form aparokṣa occurs four times; the two should be made consistent.

The copyright line prints “Preeti Thakar”; the intended form appears to be “Preeti Thakur.”

The numbered account of the three kinds of transformation lacks a short connecting sentence that would make the exposition flow more smoothly.

A future edition could add a Maithili–Sanskrit glossary of technical terms, distinguish sūtra, Bhāṣya, and commentary typographically, and provide an index of adhikaraṇas, making consultation easier for researchers.

In addition, the present file contains some apparent production artefacts: spaces between words sometimes collapse, while letters in headings occasionally appear repeated or separated, as in “anuvā nu da,” “sūtrasū,” and “mūlyā mū ṅkana.” Roman-script material and URLs also appear fragmented in certain places. Some of these defects may be introduced during document text extraction, so they should not all be treated as faults in the original DOCX without inspecting the printed pages. They should, however, be checked in the final visual prepress examination.

12. Critical Limitations and Directions for a Future Edition

Despite the work’s merits, certain limitations are evident. First, there is considerable repetition between Chapters One and Two. Second, the translator himself is also the reviewer within the book, so the critical chapters naturally display a predominantly appreciative tone. A future edition would be stronger academically if it included an independent external scholar’s disagreements, specific Sanskrit textual variants, and line-by-line comparisons with other translations.

Third, the Bhāmatī–Vivaraṇa distinctions, modern translation theory, and comparisons with Western philosophy are useful, but at certain points this broader background depends on classifications made after the original Catuḥsūtrī text. It would therefore be more useful to scholars to distinguish visually three levels: “directly present in the original,” “developed within the later Bhāmatī tradition,” and “modern comparative interpretation.”

Fourth, the structure of the bilingual file needs greater clarity. A preface explaining the English repetition after the Maithili portion, a separate half-title, or an explicit designation “English companion edition” would give readers a clearer sense of direction.

13. Conclusion and Overall Literary-Philosophical Judgment

The value of Bhāmatī (Catuḥsūtrī) does not lie merely in historical pride. The real question is whether Vācaspati Miśra’s complex philosophical

disputation can proceed in Maithili without intellectual loss. This book's answer is, for the most part, yes.

The conflict between subject and object in adhyāsa, the status of illusion, and the self-luminosity of the self; qualification, renunciation, action, and knowledge in the first sūtra; the causality of Brahman in the second; the authority of scripture in the third; the rejection of injunction-centred interpretation, object-governed knowledge, the efficacy of statements concerning an already established reality, the non-production of liberation, the dispute over difference and non-difference, and liberation while living in the fourth—all successively test the capacities of philosophical Maithili. The translation repeatedly passes those tests.

Its literary strength lies in the fact that the language does not become lifeless amid the rigour of reasoning. Words such as muskī (smile), ijot (light), anhār (darkness), bhūsī (husk), okhalī (mortar), keñchulī (slough), and bāḅī (anthill) coexist naturally with discussions of Brahman, self, ignorance, liberation, and valid cognition. Philosophy is not thereby "simplified" into the people's language; rather, the people's language proves itself capable of carrying philosophy.

The bibliography raises this translation from an isolated literary accomplishment to a resource for research. By supplying original Sanskrit editions, later commentaries, modern studies, digital collections, and methods of verifying rare works, it enhances the book's academic usefulness.

Taken as a whole, therefore, this is a significant book in three fields: Maithili philosophical prose, literature in translation, and Mithila's intellectual tradition. Its foremost strengths are the unbroken sequence of the source arguments, disciplined use of classical terminology, and natural Maithili prose. Its principal editorial needs are to regularise small textual inconsistencies, remove unnecessary editorial residues, clarify the different functions of Chapters One and Two, visually distinguish sūtra, Bhāṣya, and commentary, and state clearly the publishing design of the Maithili and English halves.

In the final assessment, this is not merely a translation of Bhāmatī; it demonstrates a developed mode of conducting philosophical argument in Maithili prose. Vācaspati's philosophy acquires not simply Maithili words but a Maithili voice.

From the finest debate over theories of erroneous appearance in the Adhyāsabhāṣya to the immense disputation of the Samanvayādhikaraṇa, no link in the reasoning has broken, nor has the language lost its breath. Vācaspati's humble image, "Just as water from the royal road becomes pure when it enters the stream of the Ganges," may be applied in reverse to this translation: the ācārya's Ganges has now come to the roads of Mithila, and

every traveller may bathe in it. This work will remain a point of reference for Maithili philosophical literature for a long time, and readers of this edition will naturally await the arrival in Maithili of the rest of Bhāmatī, from the remaining portion of its first chapter through its fourth chapter.

79. Ātmatattvaviveka: An Integrated, Extended Synopsis and Critical Evaluation

Abstract

Philosophical background, Indian and Western literary theory, translation criticism, linguistic achievement and editorial examination. Udayanācārya's Ātmatattvaviveka—also designated in the tradition as Bauddhadhikkāra or Bauddhādhikāra—is among the important works of disputation in Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika philosophy in which the debate between Buddhist and Nyāya thinkers assumes an exceptionally rigorous logical form. Gajendra Thakur's Maithili translation makes the philosophical reasoning of this work available within Mithila's modern linguistic sphere.

Keywords: Ātmatattvaviveka · integrated · extended · treatise · synopsis · critical · evaluation · criticism

Abstract · Abstract

This chapter examines "Ātmatattvaviveka: An Integrated, Extended Synopsis and Critical Evaluation". Its focus is philosophical background, Indian and Western literary theory, translation criticism, linguistic achievement and editorial examination. Udayanācārya's Ātmatattvaviveka, known in the tradition also as Bauddhadhikkāra or Bauddhādhikāra, is a major Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika work of disputation in which Buddhist and Nyāya debates assume an intensely rigorous logical form. Gajendra Thakur's Maithili translation makes the philosophical reasoning of this work accessible in Mithila's modern linguistic sphere. As a genre, it is classical prose founded on a continuous succession of pūrvapakṣa and uttarapakṣa.

Philosophical background, Indian and Western literary theory, translation criticism, linguistic achievement and editorial examination

1. Introduction and the Work's Overall Character

Udayanācārya's Ātmatattvaviveka—also referred to traditionally as Bauddhadhikkāra or Bauddhādhikāra—is among the important Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika works of philosophical disputation in which debate between Buddhist and Nyāya philosophers assumes an intensely rigorous logical form. Gajendra Thakur's Maithili translation makes the philosophical reasoning of this work accessible within the modern linguistic world of Mithila.

As a genre, this is classical philosophical prose constructed through an unbroken succession of pūrvapakṣa (the opponent's position) and uttarapakṣa (the response). Its four principal fronts examine momentariness, idealism, the alleged identity of a quality and its bearer, and the doctrine of no-self; the inquiry then reaches the self, God, the authority of scripture and liberation. Its final sequence of contemplative

stages presents the successive philosophical systems as stages along a path of spiritual practice.

The present expanded publication is not merely a translation but a study edition. It brings together the Maithili translation of the Sanskrit work, philosophical exposition, criticism informed by Indian and Western literary theory, reflection on translation theory, research materials, a substantial subject-annotated bibliography and an English presentation. The publication details give 2004 as the first edition and 2026 as the expanded edition.

This many-layered arrangement enables readers to encounter, in one volume, Udayana's philosophy, its rebirth in Maithili, critical interpretation and research resources. Such breadth is a strength of the work; at the same time, it partly accounts for the repetition of critical material in the original expanded edition.

Even the cover of the opening pages gives visual form to the publication's Mithila-centred cultural purpose. A border inspired by Mithila painting, together with folk motifs of the sun, birds, flowers and elephants, presents the philosophical book as a cultural object rather than a dry academic treatise.

If Sanskrit is the work's original scholarly language, Maithili is a language deeply connected with its geographical and cultural setting. In that sense, the translation becomes a living bridge between the source tradition and contemporary Maithili readers.

2. Historical and Philosophical Background

The intellectual conflict between Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and Buddhist philosophy in the Indian philosophical tradition was profound, prolonged and marked by remarkable logical sophistication. According to the historical account presented here, the foundations of this great debate had already been laid when Vātsyāyana wrote his commentary on the Nyāya-sūtra in the second century CE and criticised the positions of eminent Mādhyamika and Yogācāra Buddhist philosophers such as Nāgārjuna and Vasubandhu. Later, Buddhist logicians such as Dignāga, Dharmakīrti, Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla mounted sharp attacks on Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika, to which Naiyāyikas such as Uddyotakara, Trilocana and Vācaspati Miśra responded. The account describes Udayanācārya's enduring Ātmatattvaviveka, composed in the tenth or eleventh century on the soil of Kariyan village in Mithila, as the final and decisive culmination of this millennium-long debate.

The central purpose of Udayanācārya's treatise is to examine and refute Buddhist theories of momentariness, idealism, the identity of a quality and its bearer, and no-self, while establishing the reality of the self and God as

understood by Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika. The work also prepares an integrated ground for Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika metaphysics.

The intellectual atmosphere of the tenth and eleventh centuries was exceptionally contentious. In the account given here, Udayana's chief Buddhist opponents in this great logical contest were Jñānaśrīmitra and his disciple Ratnakīrti. Jñānaśrīmitra was regarded as a major pillar of Vikramaśīla Mahāvihāra, and the Jñānaśrīmitranibandhāvalī and Ratnakīrtinibandhāvalī contained vigorous critiques of Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika epistemology and metaphysics. In Ātmatattvaviveka, Udayana explicitly names Jñānaśrīmitra and refutes his position. The later eminent Naiyāyika Śaṅkara Miśra, in his Kalpalatā commentary, is said to confirm that Jñānaśrīmitra was a principal target of Udayana's attacks; Kalpalatā refers to him repeatedly. The source narrative goes on to claim that, through this tradition of argument and counterargument, Buddhist philosophers' logical positions were so weakened that the decline of Buddhist logic in India after Udayana became assured.

Udayanācārya's Ātmatattvaviveka is an important transitional point between classical Nyāya and Navya-Nyāya. Its logical subtlety was such, the account argues, that scholars of Mithila and Bengal later built on it in developing Navya-Nyāya. After Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya composed the Tattvacintāmaṇi in the fourteenth century, the stream of Navya-Nyāya that flowed from it had, in this account, already been seeded in Udayana's work. Subsequently, leading Naiyāyikas such as Pakṣadhara Miśra, Śaṅkara Miśra (Kalpalatā), Raghunātha Śiromaṇi (Dīdhiti), Bhagīratha Ṭhakkura and Mathurānātha Tarkavāgīśa wrote serious commentaries associated with Ātmatattvaviveka, further strengthening its philosophical standing. Gajendra Thakur's Maithili translation presents the difficult meanings of the original to contemporary readers in light of this commentary tradition.

At certain points, the research-based exposition makes the strong historical claim that Udayana's attacks decisively undermined the foundations of Buddhist logic in India. A comprehensive critical perspective, however, requires caution in reading such statements. The historical transformation of Buddhism and Buddhist philosophy resulted from numerous social, institutional, political and intellectual causes. Treating one book as the sole cause risks reducing a complex history to a narrative of victory.

3. Structure, Contents and Character of the Study Edition

The detailed table of contents following the publication details serves as an intellectual map of the volume. In the original expanded edition, literary and cultural criticism is followed by research essays on Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and Buddhist thought, then more rigorous textual-critical

examinations, and thereafter the Maithili translation of the original work's four parts. From the outset, the contents display the complete argumentative journey: momentariness, apoha, idealism, parts and wholes, self, God, scriptural authority and liberation.

The utility of this extensive table of contents is exceptional. Udayana's disputational treatise is by nature a dense web of positions, alternatives, objections, replies, renewed objections and conclusions. Editorial headings make it intelligible. Yet a fundamental editorial question remains: which headings belong to the original Sanskrit text, and which were supplied by the translator-editor? Without a clear indication of the distinction, researchers cannot immediately identify the boundary between translation and interpretation.

In genre, Ātmatattvaviveka is a treatise of philosophical debate. The Maithili edition makes the original's difficult sequence of arguments easier to study by dividing it into four parts and more than 405 subject-specific headings. These guide readers through the closely packed sequence of alternatives, counterpositions, objections, replies and renewed objections. For a research edition, however, original headings and editorial additions must be clearly distinguished.

The Maithili translation of the primary text begins explicitly on Appendix page 79. After the invocatory verses, it proceeds to the questions under consideration, rival doctrines and an examination of the inference offered in support of universal momentariness.

4. Extended Synopsis of the Treatise

4.1 Part One — Refutation of the Doctrine of Momentariness

4.1.1 Invocation, Identification of the Subject and the Question of Establishing Invariable Concomitance

The treatise begins with verses of praise in which Udayana salutes his teachers and chosen deity, setting the stage for the subsequent journey of reasoning. The issue is stated clearly: in the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika view, the self is an eternal, enduring substance, whereas the Buddhist position vigorously contests this and regards all existents as momentary. The Buddhist side first advances an inference: everything that exists is momentary because existence and momentariness are invariably concomitant (avinābhāva). Udayana attacks the very basis of the inference: the alleged invariable concomitance has not been established, since no valid means of knowledge proves it.

4.1.2 First Series of Refutations of Apoha Theory

The Buddhist side appeals to the theory of apoha, according to which the meaning of a word consists solely in the exclusion of other things, to

establish invariable concomitance. Udayana challenges this from several directions. How can different exclusions arise among things that exclude one another? How can partial inclusion and partial exclusion be possible within exclusions? How can distinctions in exclusion be established by differences in adventitious properties? And how can merely distinct cognitions make exclusions distinct? On each of these four questions, the alternatives proposed by the Buddhist side are rejected.

The practical dimension of the apoha controversy is also important. If "cow" means only "not non-cow", one must already possess some positive acquaintance with a cow to understand "non-cow"; the account thus incurs the defect of mutual dependence. In ordinary action, too, a person does not set out to draw water thinking, "This is not a non-pot", but acts on the positive cognition, "This is a pot."

4.1.3 The Debate over Causal Capacity: The Argument from the Necessary Sequence of Cause and Effect

The debate next centres on sāmarthya, the capacity to produce an effect. The Buddhist side argues that a cause's productive capacity can exist in three forms, but Udayana refutes all three in turn. The first is rejected outright; the second receives a detailed refutation involving successive proposals of new proofs and their rejection; a fresh reason is advanced to refute the third, and that reason too is defeated. The meanings of delayed and immediate productivity are clarified. At the conclusion of the inquiry, Udayana examines three possible formulations of the claim that only a productive cause can join with auxiliary causes, drawing out their ironic consequences—including the absurd need to group unrelated things such as donkeys and camels together. Alternative proofs, including an inferential formulation, are advanced for the view that seedhood determines sprouthood; the objection that a seed produces its effect when joined with auxiliary conditions is also answered.

4.1.4 The Argument from Contradiction: One and the Same Thing Cannot Be Both Productive and Unproductive

Udayana now offers a new and forceful argument: one and the same individual thing cannot, at one time, be both productive and unproductive. If a causal entity is unproductive without auxiliary conditions and productive when they are present, it follows on this reasoning that the entity itself has changed—a result directed against the doctrine of momentariness. Different kinds and examples of contradiction are considered, and the first two forms are rejected. Can the same substance possess different magnitudes at different times? This question receives extensive discussion, as do the objections to the coexistence of capacity and incapacity. The possibility of positing a distinct cause for each production at a distinct place, and the pair of inferences proposed to prove

the coexistence of contrary properties, are both refuted in detail. Objections concerning inconsistency in the conjunction of auxiliary causes, and concerning that conjunction's non-pervasive occurrence (avyāpyavṛttitva), are also rejected one by one.

4.1.5 Unreal Objects, Absence and the Determinants of Word Meaning

The argument turns to talk about unreal or nonexistent things. Is reference to something unreal, such as a hare's horn, self-contradictory? Can properties be ascribed to what does not exist? Is practice determined by cognition alone? These positions are examined and refuted. A significant subsection identifies and tests what determines the meaning of a word, rejecting the account that makes latent impressions (saṃskāra or vāsanā) the decisive factor. How can the signifying relation of the expression "hare's horn" be known when its referent is unreal? Each proposed answer —including alternative means and individual mental dispositions—is rejected in succession. Next comes the nature of negation or absence: can absence become an object of discourse without valid cognition, and are positive and negative entities merely mutual exclusions? The replies aim to establish the legitimate cognition both of a thing and of its negation.

4.1.6 The Argument from the Necessity of Destruction and Its Many-Sided Refutation

In support of momentariness, the Buddhist side presents a fresh argument: destruction is inevitable; therefore, existence must be momentary. Udayana takes three possible interpretations of this alleged necessity—the identity of destruction and the destroyed object, the necessity of nonexistence, and a final formulation—and refutes each in turn, including its internal alternatives. Several objections and answers concern the relation between destruction and its counterpositive (pratiyogin). The defects of the Buddhist inferences are then systematically identified and logically confirmed. A decisive turn comes when Udayana presents affirmative arguments for the persistence of objects. This is not merely refutation but a constructive proof, and the objections against it are also answered.

A simple illustration in the discussion of destruction is the pot broken by a blow from a stick. If destruction were entirely without cause, the experience of its occurrence at a particular time could not be explained. An experience such as "Now the pot has been destroyed" brings into focus the temporal, causal and counterpositive-relative character of destruction.

4.1.7 Universals (Jāti) and the Renewed, Extended Refutation of Apoha

The final and longest part of this section centres on the reality of universals (jāti or sāmānya). The nature of the common form shared by things is considered, objections advanced in favour of cognition by

exclusion are rejected, and the position of the Buddhist master Jñānaśrī—that exclusion is only a secondary object of cognition—is examined and refuted in detail. The account defends the appearance of real universals in determinate cognition. Successive inferential arguments for apoha—including the third and fourth definitions of the reason, Jñānaśrī's inference and various attempts to defend exclusion theory—are individually rejected. Dharmakīrti's view is then examined at length, together with the relation between the universal and the individual. The first part ends by supporting the sense-generated and perceptual character of determinate cognition of universals, disputing the need to accept apoha at all, and offering a final critique of Jñānaśrī's position.

4.2 Part Two — Refutation of Idealism (An Examination of the Denial of External Reality)

4.2.1 Introduction to the Debate and Identification of the Defects in the Idealist Inference

The second part examines Buddhist vijñānavāda—the view that nothing exists outside consciousness. It identifies defects in the idealist inference and develops a detailed refutation of the response offered by the Buddhist master Ratnakīrti, at points employing a style of ironic rejoinder.

4.2.2 The Debate over Variegated Cognition (Citrajñāna)

The philosophical centre of this part is the debate over citrajñāna: the simultaneous apprehension of multiple aspects, such as blue and yellow, within a single cognition. The objection that pure cognition is without differentiation is rejected. So is the claim that the appearance of incompatible qualities in cognition must be illusory. The claim that difference itself is unreal is defended by its proponents and then refuted. Detailed answers are offered to the objection that variegated cognition is neither different nor identical, and to the claim that its variegated character transcends every determination. This subsection ends with the final examination and rejection of Ratnakīrti's position.

The difference between cognition and its object is also clarified through an experience such as "I see blue": "I" is the knower, cognition is what reveals, and blue is the object known. Meaningful action is directed towards an external object, thereby strengthening the defence of an object of knowledge distinct from cognition itself.

4.2.3 The Relation between Cognition and the Known, and a Review of Various Philosophical Positions

The question now becomes: what is wrong with an object distinct from cognition being cognition's object? The account defends generic similarity in the cognition of an object, proposes and rejects successive definitions of

knowability, and ultimately also explains the Vedānta position. It then defends the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika account of the relation of cognition, rejects the Sāṃkhya and related views concerning the locus of cognition, and examines the contradictory character attributed to the Buddhist view before concluding with the purpose of Nyāya propositions. This subsection ends by rejecting the reasons advanced in negative inferences and the examples used within those inferences.

4.2.4 The Reality of a Composite Substance: The Debate over Atomism

The most extensive and logically dense part of this section establishes the reality of the composite object (avayavin), a whole such as a pot. The Buddhist side regards such a thing as merely an aggregate of atoms and denies the separate reality of the whole. Objections to the reality of difference are followed by successive defences of different accounts of difference—the first, second and third. The seventh and eighth theses receive defence and partial acceptance. There follows a series of objections to the reality of the whole—first, second, third and others—and their refutation. This pattern recurs across several subcycles: new objections founded on denying atoms, a refutation of the Mādhyamika or emptiness-based position, rejection of the claim that the cognition of gross magnitude is false, defence and criticism of the recognition of unity among atoms, discussion of the claim that imperceptible atoms cannot be perceived, and the thesis that gross magnitude determines sensory accessibility. The overall conclusion is that none of the objections to the reality of external composite objects withstands scrutiny. The section closes by rejecting an argument constructed through a conditional reversal of consequences and an insistence on inferential proof of the composite object.

The question of the gross, visible object becomes decisive in the debate over wholes. If a pot were merely an aggregate of invisible atoms, how could the simple collection of many invisible parts produce visible grossness? The Nyāya side explains gross magnitude as a new property of the whole arising from the conjunction of its parts.

4.2.5 A General Objection to External Objects and the Debate over Intrinsic Validity

A general objection to the reality of external objects is introduced and rejected, followed by a defence of the possibility of false determinate cognition and a rival explanation of ignorance of difference, which is itself answered. After rejecting the extreme alternative that “all cognition is false”, the discussion turns to svataḥprāmāṇya—the claim that cognition reveals its own validity and needs no external warrant. This position is defended; two successive objections to it are raised and rejected. A rival theory, according to which truth is known through reflective or second-

order cognition (parāmarśajñāna), receives extended criticism, including an answer to why a duality of truth and falsity need not arise within such reflection. The second part concludes with an explanation of the distinction between waking and dreaming.

4.3 Part Three — The Dispute over the Difference between Qualities and Their Substantial Substratum

This is the shortest of the four parts, but it is no less tightly argued. The Buddhist challenge is that if qualities—colour, touch and the like—and their substratum, substance, are held to be identical, the independent existence of a substance such as the self disappears, leaving only momentary cognitions. Udayana takes the reidentification of the same object by sight and touch as evidence, proposes five possibilities—a single quality, an aggregate of qualities, an entity distinct from its qualities, an unreal form, and a wholly nonexistent entity—and considers and rejects the alternatives in sequence. Four possible grounds for grouping qualities —a common substratum, simultaneity, a common effect and a common cause—are examined and rejected; the third overall possibility, that a substance is the substratum of its qualities, is accepted. Proofs advanced for the identity of qualities and substratum, including an example of a white conch appearing yellow because of a disorder of bile, are refuted in detail. Differences in the clarity or indistinctness of an object seen from near and far are then used to confirm the distinction between substance and quality. The part ends with a subtle question concerning the relation between indeterminate and determinate cognition, preparing the ground for what follows.

4.4 Part Four — Refutation of No-Self, Proof of the Self and God, and the Question of Liberation

4.4.1 Refutation of the Proof That "The Self Is Not Known"

The final and most extensive part begins with the Buddhist side's central claim: the self is not known and therefore does not exist. Udayana treats the inference as dependent on the Buddhists' own assumptions and shows that its reason, non-apprehension, is vitiated by dependence on the very self whose existence is at issue. Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika explicitly regards the self as knowable and directly apprehensible; hence, on Udayana's analysis, the inference collapses in the face of assumptions not shared by the opponent.

4.4.2 Proof of Self-Cognition and Its Defence

Evidence for the reality of the self is presented and defended. The objection that the self must be unreal because the external senses do not know it is rejected: such reasoning would also deprive consciousness's self-awareness of a foundation. The alternative that the body itself might be the object of self-knowledge is likewise rejected. So is the Yogācāra

Buddhist contention that consciousness itself is the self. Udayana develops a parallel argument from the expressions "I cut" and "I know" to establish a distinction between the agent (self) and the act (cognition).

The proof of the self in the fourth part reaches the immediate awareness "I exist". This awareness is regarded as neither merely verbal, nor inferential, nor simply a memory: it is invoked in defence of a direct apprehension of the self.

4.4.3 Recognition as an Inference: Proof of the Self's Unity

The chief inference establishing the self is based on recognition (pratyabhijñā): the identification of one and the same object through distinct experiences such as seeing and touching. Objections to its validity —including the apparently deceptive recognition of one continuously burning lamp flame—receive detailed replies. A prolonged debate follows over the definition of material causation and the relation between cause and effect. Through examples involving teacher and pupil, the newborn child's memory of a previous life, the causal relation of pot and shards, and the transformation of wood into charcoal, the discussion seeks to show that momentariness cannot adequately explain genuine material causation, whereas a doctrine of the enduring self can. Further proofs of the identity of the agent, supported by reasoning from the reversal of an undesirable consequence (prasaṅga-viparyaya), carry the argument forward.

The argument from memory and recognition also bears on moral continuity. If the agent who performs an action and the experiencer who receives its result are wholly distinct momentary beings, the defects of kṛtapraṇāśa—the loss of the fruit of an action one has performed—and akṛtābhyāgama—receiving the fruit of an action one has not performed—arise. Thus the question of the self becomes not only metaphysical but also one of moral accountability.

4.4.4 The Need for Self-Knowledge and the Proof of Discriminative Knowledge of Self and Non-Self

After raising and refuting two successive objections to the necessity of self-knowledge, Udayana turns to scriptural evidence in support of discriminative knowledge of self and non-self. Scriptural support is supplied for the position, setting the stage for a proof of the authority of scripture that will be connected to the subsequent argument for God.

4.4.5 The Proof of God: An Inferential Argument for a Creator

The most philosophically ambitious part of this section is the proof of God. Three successive objections to the inference are presented and rejected, and an extensive response is given to the fundamental objection that knowledge of invariable concomitance is impossible. The argument

that being embodied is a limiting condition (upādhi) of agency, and that creation therefore cannot establish God's existence, is refuted; second and third objections to the invariable concomitance are also rejected. After the form of the concomitance required by inference is clarified, three successive matters are examined: refutation of the position that God is not omniscient, demonstration of the authority of scripture and proof of divine omniscience. A subtle discussion of the sense of the word "greatness" and the claim that scriptural authority receives support from an immemorial tradition bring the section to its conclusion.

The well-known inference for God, "kṣityādikaṃ sakartṛkaṃ kāryatvāt ghaṭavat", means that the earth and similar things are effects and therefore raise the question of a maker, just as a pot has a potter. Whether embodiment is an indispensable condition of agency, the roles of cognition, desire and effort, omniscience, invariable concomitance and limiting conditions—all these make the argument considerably more complex than the simple example of pot and potter.

The example of medical science is used in the discussion of scriptural authority to elucidate the relation among a trustworthy speaker, successful practice and reliable testimony. Here the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika conception of scripture as divinely authored emerges as distinct from the Mīmāṃsā doctrine of its non-human authorship (apauruṣeyatva).

4.4.6 Extended Examination of the Nature of Liberation

The discussion of liberation is among the most moving parts of the treatise, philosophically as well as literarily. Liberation is defined as the final and complete cessation of suffering from the self's condition, and the delicate question is raised whether cessation of suffering is desired for the sake of obtaining pleasure. Udayana here offers a profound reflection on the balance of pleasure and suffering: "Suffering is not always accompanied by a means to pleasure, but pleasure is commonly surrounded by means to suffering." Even a thing earned legitimately may contain only a small spark of pleasure, while gaining and protecting it brings innumerable days of suffering. The images of food mixed with honey and poison, and of the farmer separating grain from husk, reinforce the argument. The claim that pleasure is eternal is then refuted at length, and a subtle analysis of the eternity or non-eternity of cognition and pleasure culminates in the conception of liberation as the self's abiding in its own nature.

In Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika, apavarga signifies the final cessation of suffering. A comparative table in the work also characterises it as the complete ending of twenty-one kinds of suffering. Since pleasurable experience is held to depend on conjunction among body, mind and senses, liberation is presented not as the eternal experience of positive pleasure but as the cessation of suffering and the self's remaining in its own nature.

4.4.7 Stages of Meditation: An Unusual Conclusion Bringing the Philosophical Systems Together

The conclusion of the treatise is distinctive in the history of Indian philosophy. Describing successive stages of meditation on the self, Udayana presents the whole Indian philosophical tradition as steps along a single path of practice: at the first stage, inquiry into external objects (Mīmāṃsā and Cārvāka); at the second, the self is identified with all objects (the Tridaṇḍin view and Yogācāra Buddhism); at the third, the self is contemplated as the exclusion of all reality (Brahman-transformation theory and Buddhist emptiness or no-self); at the fourth, the self is distinguished from the world (Sāṃkhya); at the fifth, the self is treated as the sole reality (Advaita); and finally, once all latent impressions are erased, there is indeterminate knowledge of the pure self, which Nyāya calls the crowning stone of the city of liberation. Upaniṣadic statements are cited in support of and opposition to each stage. The ladder thus respects every philosophy from Cārvāka to Advaita as offering a partial glimpse of truth, while finally settling on the Nyāya understanding of indeterminate self-knowledge.

4.4.8 Closing Verse

The treatise closes with a sharp and confident verse. Udayana portrays himself as a guide to those wandering in the darkness of many rival doctrines; with the ironic simile that a painter gains no honour from the praise of a crowd of blind people, he declines unqualified admiration. The work is offered instead with the scholar's humility of taking pleasure when the learned identify its defects.

5. The Philosophical Unity of the Work and Its Narrative of Reasoning

The four parts are not separate controversies. An unfolding philosophical design connects them.

Momentariness challenges persistence; apoha challenges positive universals and linguistic reality; idealism challenges the external object of knowledge; the reduction of substance to a collection of qualities challenges substance itself; and no-self challenges the enduring knower. At each stage, Udayana first safeguards an entity without which the question at the next stage could not even arise.

If objects persist, causation becomes possible. If there is an external object of knowledge, the relation between cognition and object is meaningful. If substance exists, qualities have a substratum. If a self endures through time, memory, action and liberation are possible. God and scripture then provide a foundation for a larger cosmic order and the path to liberation.

The title Ātmatattvaviveka therefore does not refer only to the fourth part: all the preceding arguments prepare the ground for discriminative understanding of the self.

The treatise's structure may be read as a recurring cycle: "thesis → objection → question → alternative → refutation → example → conclusion". Its narrative is not driven by events but by the progressive refinement of arguments. From momentary entities to enduring objects, from consciousness to external knowables, from qualities to substance, from a succession of fleeting cognitions to the self, from self to God, and ultimately to liberation: this ascent forms a continuous intellectual narrative.

6. Criticism in the Light of Indian Literary Theory

Although the work is not primarily poetry, its dialogue, irony, examples, metaphors, questions and answers, and underlying orientation towards liberation fully justify literary analysis. Udayana's arrangement of arguments creates the experience of a "drama of knowledge": the recurring rhythm of thesis, objection, counterquestion, alternative, refutation and conclusion generates dramatic tension.

6.1 The Question of Rasa

According to Abhinavagupta, śānta-rasa is the ground or underlying basis of all rasas because it is associated with liberation as a human goal. The dominant enduring disposition of Ātmatattvaviveka is an inquiry into reality rooted in detachment (nirveda). The treatise begins with a longing for the absolute cessation of suffering and ends with indeterminate self-knowledge, the crowning stone of the city of liberation. In this view, the argumentative journey across all four parts supplies the determinants of śānta-rasa, and each exchange of attack and reply functions like a transitory state contributing to that supreme tranquillity.

Yet within śānta as the governing rasa, an intellectual form of vīra-rasa —what might be called the heroic rasa of reasoning or knowledge—pulses throughout. Its enduring disposition is energy and resolve: the systematic defeat of each alternative, the firm one-word blow "No", and the deployment of prasaṅga-viparyaya fill the prose with force. Humour and irony are also far from absent. Describing the acceptance of incompatible cognitions as giving birth to "a monster that itself destroys all those cognitions", or comparing an impossible grouping to donkeys and camels, displays a wit uncommon in scholastic prose. The fourth part's discussion of liberation also offers a distinct glimpse of karuṇa-rasa: the portrayal of a world rich in suffering, and statements such as "even heavenly pleasure is

pierced through by the arrows of suffering", reveal a deep sense of dispassion towards the transience of worldly existence.

The concept of "heroism in reasoning" is critically productive, but it must not become a proclamation of sectarian victory. Language such as "complete and final defeat" diminishes historical complexity. A clear distance must be maintained between the heroic quality of literature and claims made in historiography.

6.2 The Question of Dhvani

By Ānandavardhana's criteria, scholastic works generally fall into the category of citra, in which the literal meaning predominates over suggestion. Yet several levels of vastu-dhvani are active in Ātmatattvaviveka. The first is a suggestion of the dignity of the self: the implied meaning of the entire sequence of refutations is that human recognition, memory, agency and moral responsibility depend on the self's endurance; to accept momentariness would be to negate every experience of one's life. The second concerns the relation between language and reality: the critique of apoha suggests that words are connected not merely to negation but to real being. The third and deepest suggestion lies in the architecture of the stages of meditation. The refutation of an earlier philosophical system need not amount to its wholesale dismissal, but can acknowledge a partial truth and transcend it. This structure suggests that truth is a progressive, cumulative process and that the Indian philosophical traditions participate in a single, integrated journey. Such an implication is never directly asserted in those words, yet it emerges from the design of the conclusion and constitutes one of the treatise's most far-reaching meanings.

A modern level of suggestion concerns the philosophical capacity of Maithili itself. Terms such as apoha, avinābhāva, sahopalambha, pratyabhijñā, anyonyābhāva, upādhi, savikalpaka and nirvikalpaka become active within Maithili syntax, suggesting that the language can do more than describe philosophy: it can itself become a medium for philosophical argument.

6.3 The Question of Vakrokti

In the terms of Kuntaka's theory of vakrokti, the dominant obliqueness of this work lies in the ordering of episodes and the construction of sentences. The sequence of questions and answers—"Should one accept that ...? No."—does not permit the reader to remain a passive listener. After each "Should ...?", readers think briefly about an answer of their own; Udayana's subsequent "No" then confronts them with the inadequacy of that inference. The unending alternation of pūrvapakṣa and uttarapakṣa—an objection to an answer already given, its renewed refutation and another objection in turn—weaves a web of structural

obliqueness in which readers can never be certain where an argument will stop. Figures of speech include abundant examples (seed and sprout, rope and snake, the fool who mistakes an elephant at a palace gate for a dark cloud or shadow, the natural enmity of snake and mongoose, and the white conch appearing yellow because of a disorder of bile); metaphors become dense at the close ("the crowning stone of the city of liberation", "an arrow that strikes its target"); and the final verse possesses the flavour of ironic praise. The painter gains no dignity from the admiration of the blind: instead of mere self-celebration, the image demands competence from the reader.

6.4 Guṇa, Rīti and Aucitya

In terms of stylistic qualities, Udayana's prose displays both ojas (vigour) and prasāda (lucidity). Vigour predominates in the passages of refutation, where the recurrent "No" falls like a thunderbolt; lucidity and sweetness characterise the discussion of liberation and the verses of praise. Judged by Kṣemendra's criterion of propriety (aucitya), each technical expression—avinābhāva, apoha, sahopalambha, prasaṅga-viparyaya, upādāna-kāraṇa, savikalpaka–nirvikalpaka, parasparāśraya and anyathānupapatti—appears in a context appropriate to its precise sense. The rigour of scholastic prose is therefore protected even as each argumentative stage maintains dramatic movement. From the standpoint of rīti, the work approaches the Vaidarbhī manner: brief, clear sentences with few compounds, preventing the subtleties of reasoning from becoming burdensome.

The obliqueness of question and answer is also a stylistic achievement of the translation. Short signals such as "What?", "No", "Then?" and "But?" lend a Maithili orality to Sanskrit disputation. Technical terms have not been forcibly replaced by homely synonyms; their historically distinctive meanings are therefore preserved.

6.5 Figures of Speech and Poetic Indication

Finally, the close relation between figures of meaning—illustration, metaphor, ironic praise and the presentation of a supporting meaning—and the logical architecture of Ātmatattvaviveka lies in their status as more than decoration. They become parts of proof: an illustration is itself a miniature argument; a metaphor condenses a conclusion. In this respect, the treatise is a rare instance of Indian śāstra literature in which reasoning and poetic expression become inseparable within the same sentence.

7. Western Literary Theory and a Comparative Philosophical Rereading

7.1 Socratic–Platonic Dialectic and Dramatic Dialogue

As in Plato's Dialogues, truth emerges in Ātmatattvaviveka not through direct proclamation but through elenchus, the Socratic procedure of questions and counterquestions that exposes internal inconsistency in an opponent's view. Each of Udayana's "No" replies works like the moment of a Socratic elenchus when an interlocutor is forced to recognise the contradiction in their own claim. There is, however, an important difference. Platonic dialogues often end with an unresolved question, or aporia; Udayana's treatise begins with such uncertainty but concludes by establishing determinate doctrines—the self, God and liberation. In that respect it approaches Aristotle's systematic treatise more closely than Platonic dialogue, although its dramatic form, with the imagined opponent's voice and recurring exchange of questions, remains Platonic in character.

7.2 Aristotle's Rhetoric and Poetics

All three means of persuasion described in Aristotle's Rhetoric—ethos (the credibility of the speaker), pathos (the audience's emotional involvement) and logos (logical demonstration)—can be discerned in Ātmatattvaviveka. Logos is naturally predominant: inference, reasons and examples follow the structure of Nyāya reasoning. Ethos arises from Udayana's repeated and apparently fair presentation of the opposing view. Rather than weakening the opponent's position before attacking it, he seeks to state it in its strongest form and only then refute it—a practice that might now be called steel-manning. Pathos, through irony, examples and the emotional appeal of the discussion of liberation (especially its account of pervasive suffering), connects the purely logical genre with the reader's feeling. A philosophical counterpart of catharsis, as described in Aristotle's Poetics as the purgation of pity and fear at the end of tragedy, may also be discerned here. After the prolonged and often painful journey of objection and reply, the movement towards the indeterminate tranquillity of liberation functions as a kind of intellectual catharsis in which the reader passes through the "fear" of logical conflict into the calm of self-knowledge.

7.3 Bakhtin's Dialogism and Polyphony

Seen through Mikhail Bakhtin's theories of dialogism and polyphony, Ātmatattvaviveka is an unusual text. For Bakhtin, in a fully dialogical work different voices converse on terms of relative equality, with no voice wholly subordinating all others. In Udayana's work, the Buddhist pūrvapakṣa—the views of Ratnakīrti, Jñānaśrī and Dharmakīrti—does

not enter merely as a puppet set up to be knocked down. These arguments are presented with their own philosophical seriousness and internal logic; in several places, the succession of layered objections and replies is so extended that a reader may temporarily entertain the possibility of victory for the Buddhist side. This tension prevents the work from being a one-sided sermon and gives it the character of genuine philosophical combat, a dialectical agon. Nevertheless, it is not fully polyphonic in Bakhtin's sense, as a Dostoevskian novel might be, since the authorial position—Udayana's established doctrine—ultimately wins decisive authority. The combination of a dialogic process and a monologic conclusion may be considered a distinctive feature of classical disputational literature.

7.4 Formalism, New Criticism and Reader Response

From the perspective of the Russian Formalist concept of literariness, the literary effect of Ātmatattvaviveka owes less to its subject matter than to its devices, especially defamiliarisation (ostranenie). The recurrent form of question and reply produces a rhythmic experience in which every blow of "No" surprises the reader anew, even when the structure of the argument has become predictable. Through the close-reading method of New Criticism, the work may be considered self-contained: the internal tension and resolution of each paragraph (objection versus answer) can be analysed as a small unit reflecting the structure of the book as a whole—the part mirrors the whole. Reader-response theory, particularly Wolfgang Iser's account of gaps or Leerstellen, illuminates the demand for active participation made by the question-and-answer style. Every brief pause after "Could it be ...?" creates a gap that the reader fills with a provisional answer; the collision between that imagined answer and the answer given by the text becomes central to the reading experience.

7.5 Poststructuralism and Deconstruction

Derridean deconstruction brings out an intriguing paradox. Udayana's entire method is itself centred on refutation: it exposes internal contradictions in the opponent's concepts—for example, between momentariness and invariable concomitance, or between apoha and difference—and dismantles them. The procedure bears a structural resemblance to deconstruction, even though its aim is contrary. Derrida does not arrive at a stable final truth after dismantling a conceptual structure; Udayana uses refutation as the means of establishing one. The distinction reveals, in the critic's account, a significant difference between these intellectual orientations. Indian methods of refutation, such as Nāgārjuna's consequential reasoning or Udayana's critique of inference, often proceed dialectically towards a positive establishment, whereas postmodern deconstruction deliberately remains open to indeterminacy or

aporia. The comparison assigns the treatise a distinctive place in conversation with international literary theory.

By Bakhtin's criteria, the opposing position receives a substantial voice, but the final authority belongs to the answer or siddhānta. Thus the work is not fully polyphonic; it is a Nyāya-centred work with a dialogic structure —a dialogic process leading to a monologic conclusion.

Structurally, the oppositions enduring/momentary, cognition/known object, substance/quality, part/whole, self/non-self and truth/error bind the four parts together. Udayana reaches the internal inconsistency of an opponent's thesis and refutes it, but he does not stop at Derridean undecidability: he proceeds to positive establishment. It is therefore meaningful to describe the work as possessing a "deconstructive method with a non-deconstructionist conclusion."

7.6 Hermeneutics, Phenomenology and Reader Participation

Memory, recognition and a structure of experience such as "I, who experienced something yesterday, remember it today" offer useful material for a phenomenological study of self-experience through time. Yet Udayana's realist proof of a substantial self and modern phenomenology are not the same thing. The comparison is fruitful at the level of questions, not as a claim of doctrinal identity.

From a reader-response perspective, the questions and answers engage readers as participants. Nonetheless, editorial headings such as "unacceptable", "refutation" and "defect" may reduce the space for independent discovery by announcing conclusions in advance.

7.7 Comparative Philosophy

Recognition can be read alongside Western discussions of personal identity; the critique of idealism alongside debates about idealism; apoha alongside nominalism and realism; and the proof of God alongside arguments from design. The controversy over apoha recalls questions about nominalism and realism raised by Quine and Goodman. The distinction between cognition and its object enters into dialogue with G. E. Moore's anti-idealist arguments. Memory and recognition touch territory explored in John Locke's and Derek Parfit's discussions of personal identity. The argument from the created character of the world may be set beside William Paley's design argument.

These are primarily similarities of questions, however, rather than similarities of answers. The enduring self of Indian Nyāya, the Buddhist stream of cognitions, modern psychological continuity and Western theories of personal identity arise from different metaphysical backgrounds. Comparative reading opens horizons; it does not establish direct doctrinal equivalence.

8. Indian Perspectives on Translation: Intended Meaning, Vernacular Commentary and Maithilisation

The book understands translation not merely as the rendering of words but as an interpretation of intended meaning (tātparya) and a commentary in the target language. This approach suits the task. The translator preserves the original sequence of reasoning but unfolds lengthy Sanskrit constructions into Maithili sentences, supplies topical headings and gives the arguments an audible form through questions and replies.

A significant achievement lies in combining the foreignness of technical terminology with the local character of syntax. The word apoha is retained, but it is surrounded by Maithili sentences. Pratyabhijñā remains, while the argument from memory is developed in phrases drawn from Maithili experience. Thus the source tradition is not erased, nor does the target language become merely Sanskrit's shadow.

A distinctive feature of the translation is precisely this coexistence of specialised foreignness and syntactic domestication. Terms such as apoha and pratyabhijñā are protected, while their arguments unfold through Maithili statements of experience, question-and-answer constructions and natural connective words. The project is less a word-for-word translation than a Maithilisation of reasoning.

9. In the Light of Western Translation Theory

9.1 Foreignisation and Domestication

Viewed through Friedrich Schleiermacher and Lawrence Venuti, this translation pursues both routes at once. At the terminological level it foreignises, requiring the reader to enter Udayana's conceptual world. At the level of sentences and examples it domesticates: references to a threshing floor, donkeys and camels, and expressions such as "dear brother" make Udayana seem to speak in a Maithili courtyard. The translator does not become invisible; instead, linguistic barriers are lowered while the intellectual challenge is kept intact.

9.2 Dynamic Equivalence, the Balance between Semantic and Communicative Translation, and Purpose

By Eugene Nida's criterion of dynamic equivalence, this is a hybrid translation. It maintains formal fidelity in the structure of the arguments, yet employs dynamic equivalence at the level of sentences so that Maithili readers may experience an effect comparable to that experienced by Sanskrit-literate readers of the original. In Peter Newmark's terms, it balances semantic and communicative translation. According to Reiss and Vermeer's skopos theory, the purpose is twofold: to give Maithili the resources of philosophical prose, and to provide Maithili researchers with a

gateway into their own tradition. Its section headings and well-structured divisions make the book suitable for self-directed study.

9.3 Steiner's Four Movements and Benjamin's Afterlife

George Steiner's four movements of translation—trust, aggression, incorporation and restitution—can be identified in the translation. There is the translator's trust that this ancient work is meaningful to Maithili readers; the breaking of the original's continuous prose into 405 divisions (aggression); the incorporation of technical terminology into Maithili sentences; and the final restitution of an expanded life to Ātmatattvaviveka. In Walter Benjamin's account, translation constitutes the afterlife (Fortleben) of an original. Benjamin's belief that accomplished translation presses both source and target language towards a "pure language" is seen here as pertinent to the work's achievement.

The ideas of Steiner and Benjamin open culturally attractive routes of comparison. Methodologically, however, it is more cautious to use them as tools for comparative reading than to treat them as doctrines identical with those of the Indian translation tradition.

9.4 Polysystems, Rewriting and Retrieval

From the perspectives of André Lefevere's theory of rewriting and Itamar Even-Zohar's polysystem theory, this autonomous publication outside major institutions through the Videha e-journal constitutes a cultural and political statement. By filling what had largely been an empty place for philosophical prose within the Maithili literary system, the translation moves that genre towards the centre. It is more than one book: it establishes a prose register for future philosophical writing in Maithili. Ganesh Devy's understanding of "translation as retrieval" is particularly applicable here. Udayana had become little more than a name in Mithila's intellectual memory; the translation makes that name into a readable text once again.

9.5 Criteria Drawn from Toury, House and Berman

The translation may be understood as a combination of semantic transfer, communicative rephrasing and explanatory presentation. The coexistence of these three elements offers a useful account of the work's actual character.

From Gideon Toury's target-text perspective, acceptability in Maithili is successful, while source-oriented adequacy is preserved by technical vocabulary. Without a parallel Sanskrit base text, however, it is difficult to check fully whether anything was omitted, whether anything was added, and whether headings are original or editorial.

Juliane House's criterion for overt translation is also relevant. Historical distance has not been erased, but transparency remains incomplete without details of the base edition, textual variants and editorial interventions.

In the light of Antoine Berman's deforming tendencies, broad section headings undoubtedly make the argument easier to navigate, but they can also announce the original's uncertainties or gradually emerging conclusions prematurely. For a research edition, the neutral heading "Examination of the first alternative" would be preferable to "The first alternative is unacceptable."

10. The Achievement of Maithili and the Translator's Style

The work's most lasting achievement may be not any single philosophical conclusion but its practical demonstration of what Maithili philosophical prose can do.

The translation shows that Maithili can sustain extended divisions among alternatives, analyses of cause and effect, fallacies of inference, mutual dependence, memory, perception, inference, absence, universals, God and liberation in a continuous scholarly argument. Natural Maithili connectives—"but", "therefore", "then", "if … then", "or", "whether" and "no"—carry complex Nyāya constructions.

What matters especially is that Sanskrit terminology does not displace Maithili grammar. The skeleton of the sentence is Maithili; the Sanskrit technical term is its conceptual centre. This balance prevents the result from being either an artificial shadow of Sanskrit or oversimplified prose that sacrifices philosophical precision.

The translator's distinctive achievement may be seen in four aspects:

- Activating a philosophical vocabulary in Maithili: Sanskrit terms such as avinābhāva, pratyabhijñā and savikalpaka function within Maithili syntax.
- Controlling the weight of Sanskrit: while the conceptual centre remains Sanskrit-derived, verbs, connectives and relational expressions belong to Maithili, allowing the text to stand as independent Maithili prose.
- Giving logic an oral form: cues such as "What?", "No", "Very well", "Then" and "But" generate the audible rhythm of philosophical debate.
- A syntax of alternatives: connectives such as "otherwise", "or" and "whether … or" enable readers to follow the structure of an argument without a diagram.

For this reason, the work's most lasting linguistic achievement is not the discovery of an equivalent for any one word but the sustained

movement of extended Nyāya reasoning through Maithili sentence structures.

11. Literary Images and Udayana's Authorial Personality

Seed and sprout, pot and stick, the hare's horn, elephant, physician, blind people, painter, pleasure and suffering, the city of liberation, and arrows: if these examples were removed, the treatise might retain its logical force but would become poor as literature.

An important strength of the translation is that it does not treat these as "mere logical illustrations" but preserves their narrative energy. Humour and irony in particular bring Udayana's disputational personality into view. The reader thus encounters not a lifeless collection of formulas but the experience of a living philosophical debate.

Some examples whose severity, sectarian character or treatment of women reflects their historical period call for editorial annotation for modern readers. Such passages should not be deleted, since they form part of the historical source; it should, however, be made clear that they represent the period-bound polemical language of the original, not necessarily the values endorsed by a modern editor or translator.

12. Linguistic, Editorial and Research Limitations

The main weaknesses of the present book appear less in the translation's fundamental capabilities than in its editorial arrangement and transparency for researchers.

12.1 Base Edition and Source Transparency

Many Sanskrit editions are listed in the bibliography, but the principal base edition used for translation needs to be identified explicitly. Without the Sanskrit original printed in parallel, it is difficult to investigate fully whether something was omitted or added and whether a heading is original or editorial.

12.2 Distinguishing the Original Text from Editorial Headings

The more than 405 headings make the work easier to study, but original Sanskrit headings and those added by the translator-editor should be separately marked. A neutral research-edition heading such as "Examination of the first alternative" would be more appropriate than "The first alternative is unacceptable", since it does not announce a conclusion prematurely.

12.3 Language Policy and Consistency of Form

A consistent editorial policy is needed for variants such as khaṇḍ/khaṇḍa, the use of hyphens in compounds, certain spellings, and

verb forms corresponding to “can be”. In the Maithili critical sections, an excess of Roman-letter English expressions interrupts the flow of prose that is predominantly in Devanagari. Names of Western theories should be retained where necessary, while Maithili or Devanagari renderings of technical concepts may be made primary.

12.4 Panegyrical Historical Narration

Expressions such as “utter refutation”, “the end of Buddhist logic through one work” and “epoch-making” can move critical inquiry towards panegyric. Udayana’s philosophical importance can be acknowledged without sacrificing the multi-causal complexity of history.

12.5 Tools for Study

A fully international study edition would benefit from an explicit identification of the Sanskrit base text, selected Sanskrit passages, textual variants, markings of words and headings added by the translator, a technical glossary, a subject index and, if possible, the numbering of the original textual sections. These omissions do not diminish the readability or philosophical capacity of the translation; they concern the verifiability of research.

13. Extended Bibliography, English Half and Research Resources

At the end of the Maithili section stands an extensive, subject-arranged annotated bibliography containing ninety-nine entries. It begins with the Sanskrit original, major editions, commentaries and translations, and extends to Udayana’s other works, Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika, Buddhist logic, theories of the self, Indian poetics, translation theory, and digital manuscript resources. The bibliography also explains its own purpose.

Its final entry reaches the National Mission for Manuscripts, and an editorial note clearly states that, when preparing a critical edition, Sanskrit quotations should be checked against the printed original or a reliable manuscript.

Earlier criticism of the reference list had raised issues such as the presence of Wikipedia, commercial booksellers and general websites. The present final bibliography, however, is more refined, with ninety-nine organised entries and notes explaining their use. The portions of the older criticism that no longer apply to this version should therefore be updated in a subsequent edition.

At approximately page 291, the publication information begins again in English, restating details of the Sanskrit source, the Maithili translator and the expanded edition.

This is followed by a substantial English table of contents, critical essays, an English presentation of the original translation, and a comprehensive bibliography. The sequence places the reviews, critical studies, English presentation of the philosophical text and bibliography in an orderly arrangement.

The benefit of such a bilingual structure is considerable. Researchers who do not know Maithili can still access the work's architecture of reasoning and critical materials. Its possible readership therefore extends beyond regional boundaries.

The price of this arrangement, however, is bulk and repetition. Since the Maithili and English materials are largely duplicated within a single volume, the book becomes heavy. That may be useful for research, but separate Maithili and English editions could be more accessible to general readers.

There is also a minor editorial inconsistency: Chapter 4 of the English section is titled "Bibliography with Maithili Annotations", but the notes explaining the entries in that part are themselves in English. An English equivalent simply meaning "Extended Annotated Bibliography" would be more accurate.

14. Final Integrated Evaluation

The significance of this expanded edition of Ātmatattvaviveka rests on four levels.

Philosophically, it links momentariness, causation, language, universals, external reality, composite wholes, self, memory, God, scripture and liberation into one continuous journey of reasoning.

As translation, it does not destroy the difficult technical tradition of Sanskrit but brings it to life within the natural movement of Maithili sentences. Its central achievement is not the substitution of words but the Maithilisation of philosophical argument.

Literarily, the drama of reasoning, irony, examples, questions, seed and sprout, elephant, hare's horn, physician, blind people, painter, city of liberation and arrow striking its target generate the work's aesthetic energy. The undercurrent of śānta-rasa and the vigour of heroic reasoning prevent it from becoming a dry Nyāya treatise.

Culturally, the book does not merely claim that sophisticated philosophical prose is possible in Maithili: it demonstrates that possibility through an actual text. This is its most lasting contribution.

Its limitations are also clear: some early panegyrical excesses, ambiguity about the source edition, failure to distinguish original text from editorial intervention, too many Roman-letter terms, repeated generic headings,

partial repetition in the critical apparatus of the expanded edition, and increased bulk from the English half. Yet the present ninety-nine-entry bibliography also shows that several earlier deficiencies in research tools have already been addressed.

Ultimately, to describe this book merely as "a Maithili translation of Udayanācārya" would understate its character. It combines a rereading of the original philosophy, the creation of Maithili philosophical prose, an application of translation theory, self-critical editorial discussion, research resources and a bridge to English. Its strongest part remains the primary Maithili translation; the critical materials surrounding it extend its field of meaning, though at times their own enthusiasm needs restraint.

The work's conclusion defines liberation as the absolute cessation of suffering, turning the long logical journey towards spiritual practice, while its final verse asks critics not for blind praise but for the identification of real defects. Measured by that standard, the present edition deserves the following assessment: highly accomplished as philosophical translation, significant for Maithili intellectual history, rich as a study edition, and still requiring some clearly identifiable editorial work before it can become a fully critical edition.

80. Nyāyakusumāñjali (Udayanācārya's Maithili Translation): An Integrated, Extended Synopsis and Critical Evaluation

Abstract

In the light of Indian and Western literary theory, philosophy and translation studies — Original Sanskrit: Udayanācārya; Maithili translation: Gajendra Thakur; Publisher: Videha, ISSN 2229-547X. This integrated review examines the entire work from a single, comprehensive perspective: its preliminary publication material, table of contents, all critical and research-oriented sections from Chapters 1 to 12, the complete Maithili translation presented in five clusters of flowers, the appendices, the bibliography, and the parallel English section included in the latter part of the book.

Keywords: Nyāyakusumāñjali · Udayanācārya · translation · integrated · extended · work · synopsis · critical evaluation

In the light of Indian and Western literary theory, philosophy and translation studies — Original Sanskrit: Udayanācārya; Maithili translation: Gajendra Thakur; Publisher: Videha, ISSN 2229-547X

Abstract

This chapter examines Nyāyakusumāñjali (Udayanācārya's Maithili Translation): An Integrated, Extended Synopsis and Critical Evaluation. In the light of Indian and Western literary theory, philosophy and translation studies — Original Sanskrit: Udayanācārya; Maithili translation: Gajendra Thakur; Publisher: Videha, ISSN 2229-547X. This integrated review examines the complete work from a comprehensive perspective: its preliminary publication material, contents, critical and research-oriented sections from Chapters 1 to 12, the complete Maithili translation presented in five clusters of flowers, the appendices, bibliography, and the parallel English section in the latter portion of the volume. The work presents itself as Gajendra Thakur's translation from Udayanācārya's original Sanskrit Nyāyakusumāñjali.

1. Basis of the Review, Historical Context and Character of the Translation

This integrated review considers the work in its entirety: the initial publication material, the contents, all the critical and research sections from Chapters 1 to 12, the full Maithili translation arranged in five clusters of flowers, the appendices, bibliography and parallel English section in the latter part of the book. The work identifies itself as a translation by Gajendra Thakur from Udayanācārya's original Sanskrit Nyāyakusumāñjali. Its publication information specifies the first edition of 2004 and the expanded edition of 2026, together with responsibility for translation, editing and book design, and Videha's role as publisher.

The book's essential achievement is not simply that a Sanskrit work of Nyāya has become available in Maithili. Its real importance lies in the creation, in Maithili, of an organised philosophical prose capable of expressing the extraordinarily complex epistemology, causal theory, treatment of absence, theory of the means of knowledge,

philosophy of language, methods of debate and inference to God found in Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika. In this sense the book brings together translation, commentary, criticism, research, textual history and language-building within a single undertaking.

In the history of Indian philosophy, Udayanācārya, of the tenth–eleventh century, occupies a point of transition at which classical Nyāya begins to turn towards Navya-Nyāya. His Nyāyakusumāñjali — literally, 'an offering of flowers of reasoning' — is regarded as one of the Indian tradition's most systematic, subtle and influential philosophical treatises in defence of God's existence. Divided into five stabhakas, or clusters of flowers, it combines metrical kārikās with the author's own prose explanations. On every page unfolds the dialectical drama of pūrvapakṣa and uttarapakṣa, a mode of reasoning later brought to a high degree of refinement in Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi.

Udayanācārya is an eminent figure of Mithila, and Nyāyakusumāñjali is a fruit of thought born in Mithila's soil. Yet for more than a thousand years that fruit remained locked within the storehouse of Sanskrit: the everyday language of Mithila could not touch it. The Maithili translation by Gajendra Thakur is therefore not merely a linguistic transfer; it is a repatriation of an intellectual inheritance. Arguments once heard in Sanskrit in the assemblies, schools and halls of philosophical disputation in Mithila's settlements now speak, in an organised form, in the mother tongue of that very land. From the perspective of the parallel literary movement associated with Videha, this is an exceptional event, because translation becomes an act of decolonisation and of reclaiming one's own intellectual legacy. The translation's history is itself revealing: the first edition appeared in 2004, while the expanded 2026 edition bears witness to two decades of maturation. A translation that has lived alongside its translator for twenty years vividly demonstrates that translation is not a single event but a continuing process.

The Sanskrit Nyāyakusumāñjali has a two-layered texture of kārikā (verse) and prose exposition. This translation transforms that double structure into continuous, paragraph-based Maithili prose, marking each sequence of reasoning with a clear Maithili heading — 'Determination of the Subject of Inquiry', 'The Argument for Treating Capacity as an Independent Entity', 'Resolution of Doubt Concerning Momentariness', and so forth. This system of headings acts as a map for modern readers; in a classical text that can resemble a labyrinth, the headings stand like milestones.

In the terms of Roman Jakobson's threefold classification, all three kinds of translation are taking place here simultaneously: interlingual translation (Sanskrit into Maithili); intralingual translation (the suggestive compactness of the metrical statements combined with explanatory prose and recast as expanded, self-sufficient exposition, the commentary layer already present in the source being absorbed into the translation); and, in one sense, intersemiotic translation (a shift from the rhythmic signs of verse to the logical signs of prose).

2. The Architecture of the Entire Book: From Translation to a Multilayered Work of Knowledge

The book does not follow the ordinary pattern of 'introduction–translation–bibliography'. Its first ten chapters form a sequential record of critical, literary-theoretical, philosophical and translation-theoretical evaluations undertaken at

different stages of the translation. Chapter 11 contains the Maithili translation of all five clusters. Chapter 12 provides an extensive bibliography. Thereafter the research material and translated text are presented in parallel in English. The English section begins with its own publication information and contents.

In one respect this structure is exceptionally rich: readers encounter the translated work alongside its explanation, theory, criticism, background and comparative studies. In another respect, assembling so much material in a single volume creates an editorial difficulty. Some early chapters review a stage when the translation was incomplete, whereas later chapters were written after all five clusters had been finished. At one point, for example, the fourth and fifth stabhakas are described as 'awaited', while a later comprehensive study explicitly states that the complete five-cluster translation is available.

For this reason, the book's eventual academic form needs to label the early chapters as 'reviews written at a particular stage of the translation's development', with a date or edition reference. What presently appears to be a contradiction would then become a valuable record of the translation's twenty-two-year development.

3. The Sequential Critical Development of the Research Chapters

Chapter 1: The First Extended Review — The Translation's Literary and Linguistic Self-Understanding

Chapter 1 begins with the work, its author and translator, and its historical position. It identifies Udayanācārya as an important figure in the transition from classical Nyāya towards Navya-Nyāya, and outlines both the five-stabhaka structure of Nyāyakusumāñjali and its combination of kārikās with the author's own prose commentary.

The chapter's most successful passage is its analysis of śleṣa, or double meaning, in the auspicious invocation. In the original, flowers and doctrines of reasoning are simultaneously evoked by the same words. The translation resolves this by opening two levels, 'in the sense of a flower' and 'in the sense of a principle of Nyāya'. From the standpoint of poetry translation, dividing the effect into two does diminish the sudden brilliance of a pun that would otherwise blossom in a single instant. From the standpoint of philosophical translation, however, no meaning is lost. This decision exemplifies the method of the whole translation: accepting some loss of verbal wonder in order to preserve the completeness of meaning.

In interpreting an image such as 'the flower does not wither even when pressed', the chapter shows together the paradoxical image of the flower and the suggestion that reasoning cannot be refuted. On this basis it offers an effective reading of śleṣa, vakrokti and dhvani.

Its discussion of rasa identifies śānta as the dominant current, while finding a particular, 'heroic in argument' form of vīra in the clash of philosophical disputation and the presence of adbhuta in the intellectual wonder produced by subtle reasoning. This is a creative attempt to apply poetics to philosophical prose. The necessary qualification is that such a use of rasa should not be equated with the immediate aesthetic experience of a drama or epic; it should be understood as an interpretative tool for explaining the aesthetic effects of philosophical prose.

In discussing aucitya, or propriety, the chapter correctly identifies the translation's two-level lexical policy. Technical terms such as hetu, sādhya, vyāpti, upādhi, samavāya, pratiyogin and anvaya–vyatireka remain intact, while examples such as 'a hare's horn' are brought close to the reader in Maithili's own linguistic world. The later comprehensive study likewise regards this two-level policy as a principal achievement of the translation.

In its treatment of rīti and sentence rhythm, the chapter demonstrates how Maithili connectives such as 'if–then', 'therefore', 'but' and 'hence' can reconstruct the relations of cause and consequence in Sanskrit propositions. This is a sound observation. The translation's real linguistic achievement is not to imitate Sanskrit sentence construction, but to develop Maithili's own idiom of logical argument.

The discussion of Bhartṛhari, verbal testimony (śabda-pramāṇa) and the translation's self-referential character is particularly interesting. When the work recognises language as an independent means of knowledge, the translation itself becomes a text reflecting on word meaning, sentence meaning, the speaker, intention and the power of comprehension. The attempt to connect this with indigenous Indian sources of translation theory is an original feature of the chapter.

The Western-theory section reads the text through Bakhtin's polyphony; Schleiermacher's and Gadamer's hermeneutics; Nida, Venuti, Benjamin, Steiner, Skopos theory, Lefevere, polysystem theory, Iser and others. These comparisons are useful, but it must always remain clear that modern theories are not Udayanācārya's 'historical sources'. They are tools for contemporary interpretation.

A significant limitation of Chapter 1 is its own historical position: it was written when the fourth and fifth clusters had not yet been included in the complete translation. The chapter should therefore be seen not as a final judgment on the entire book as it now stands, but as the first critical milestone in the translation's development.

Chapter 2: The Philosophical Architecture of the Latter Half and the Depth of its Reasoning

The structure of Chapter 2 is more concentrated. It covers the reviewed portion's position within the book, its philosophical architecture, Indian poetics, the Navya-Nyāya perspective, Western philosophy, translation theory, language and style, limitations and conclusion. This full arrangement is clearly set out in the contents.

Where the first chapter focuses primarily on the literary and linguistic character of the translation, the second places greater emphasis on the underlying structure of the arguments. A special strength of Chapter 2 is its ability to see the entire sequence as an architecture: particularly the latter portion of the third cluster, the number of pramāṇas, verbal testimony, connected meaning, postulation (arthāpatti) and non-apprehension (anupalabdhi); followed by the debate over knownness (jñātatā) and the movement towards arguments for God.

From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, the discussion of the bridge from Udayana to Gaṅgeśa fits the wider purpose of the book. Historically, however, it would be more rigorous to regard this bridge as an intellectual prelude rather than as a 'direct succession of doctrines'.

From the standpoint of translation studies, Chapter 2 tries to explain why the source's compressed, aphoristic density becomes an expanded exposition in Maithili. It would be wrong to dismiss this expansion merely as 'more words'; for a modern reader

encountering Nyāya in the mother tongue, the explanation of context, the opposing position and the reply is part of the translation's purpose. Yet it is precisely here that the boundary between translation and commentary must be marked. This problem recurs across several chapters of the book.

Chapter 3: The Most Comprehensive Early Critical Examination

Chapter 3 is the most systematically organised review of the first phase. It includes a review abstract, method, an account of the work as philosophy, śāstra and literature, textual structure, Indian poetics, Western theories, Indian and modern translation traditions, close readings of selected passages, language and style, editorial apparatus, comparative evaluation, and recommendations for a revised critical edition.

The section on Indian poetics treats rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, guṇa, rīti, aucitya, alaṅkāra and illustrative examples separately. A major strength of this chapter is that it does not treat Nyāyakusumāñjali merely as a book of arguments for God's existence; it also recognises the aesthetic functions of its title, flower imagery, dialogic construction, pūrvapakṣa and uttarapakṣa, examples and closing prayer.

The Western section ranges from Aristotelian logic and rhetoric to Russian Formalism, New Criticism, structuralism, Bakhtinian dialogism, hermeneutics, reader-response theory and deconstruction. This breadth is impressive, but it is also a weakness: when so many theories are applied to the same text at once, the names of theories sometimes outweigh the actual analysis. A sustained application of two or three selected approaches can sometimes produce more than brief applications of ten.

The chapter tests the translation against criteria drawn from Nida, Newmark, Skopos theory, domestication and foreignisation, Catford, Toury, polysystem theory, Berman and Steiner. One conclusion emerges from this varied examination: the translation is neither wholly domesticated nor wholly oriented towards Sanskrit. Its technical lexicon comes from the Sanskrit tradition, but its argumentative sentences and examples turn towards the Maithili reader.

Close readings of representative passages — the four meanings of 'akasmāt', the causality of absence, the Sāṅkhya, Cārvāka and Buddhist positions, prāmāṇya, the impermanence of words, non-apprehension and non-existence, inference and upādhi, comparison and testimony, and connected meaning — give the chapter a genuine critical foundation. They prevent it from becoming merely a display of theoretical names.

The editorial section is extremely important. For a future critical edition, the book itself proposes separate arrangements for the original Sanskrit text, fluent Maithili translation, philosophical explanation, footnotes, a glossary of technical terms, indexes and a parallel digital display. This remains among the most useful editorial directions offered anywhere in the volume.

Chapter 3, too, belongs to a stage when only part of the text was available. Where it remarks on 'incompleteness', therefore, that is not a defect of the present, complete translation but a document of an earlier state.

Chapter 4: A Chapter of Rigorous Self-Criticism

Chapter 4 is a second extended review in the light of Indian and Western literary and translation theories. Its examination ranges across rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, alaṅkāra, rīti, guṇa and aucitya; Formalism, New Criticism, structuralism, reader-response

theory, hermeneutics, deconstruction and rhetoric; formal and functional equivalence; semantic and communicative translation; domestication and foreignisation; Skopos; explicitation by the translator; technical terminology; the quality of Maithili; repetition; editorial errors; ideology; achievements and limitations; pre-publication corrections; and evaluation.

The distinctive feature of this chapter is its rigorous self-criticism rather than its praise. In its earlier state, it raised questions about the improper merging of two headings, the incompleteness of the final sentence, unclear sources of quotations and blurred boundaries between the voices of the author, commentator and translator. Its earlier evaluation table awarded comparatively high marks for philosophical communication and sequence of reasoning, but lower marks for the critical editorial apparatus and readiness for immediate publication.

It would be inappropriate to reproduce that judgment unchanged as the final verdict on the present complete work, because later chapters themselves announce the completion of all five clusters. The chapter becomes much more valuable if retained as a historical inspection report on textual revision. It allows readers to see how the work reached its final form.

Chapter 5: Maithili Language, History, Script, Institutions and Modernity

Chapter 5 does more than analyse the text of Nyāyakusumāñjali; it relates the translation to Maithili's wider social and intellectual environment. It discusses Maithili's historical position, demographic reach, linguistic structure, phonology, 'null-subject' grammar, dialects and standardisation, modern digital language technology, Mithilākṣara/Tirhuta, Unicode, philosophical traditions, Videha, the parallel literary movement, educational institutions and contemporary dissemination. Varṇaratnākara and Vidyāpati also appear in the account of linguistic history.

The chapter's intellectual purpose is clear: to treat the translation of Nyāyakusumāñjali not as an isolated book, but as part of a wider project to increase Maithili's modern capacity as a language of knowledge. Its account of Videha and the parallel literary movement belongs to the same framework.

This expansion is important, but it is in this chapter that particular care with sources is most necessary. Population figures, university curricula, Unicode, institutions, modern digital language technology and digital projects are all subject to change. Each such claim should therefore be accompanied by a clear year, source and footnote. Otherwise time-specific information embedded within the work's enduring philosophical discussion may quickly become outdated.

The philosophical portion connects śleṣa and vakrokti, the five atheistic objections, the Mīmāṃsā concepts of adṛṣṭa and capacity, Sāṅkhya, Cārvāka, Buddhist momentariness, verbal testimony and Western theories. The chapter thereby links language history to philosophy. Structurally, however, dividing it into two separate chapters — 'History of the Maithili Language' and 'The Translation's Philosophical Significance' — might have given it greater concentration.

Chapter 6: The Philosophical Depth of Epistemology and Arguments for God

Chapter 6 is among the book's principal chapters devoted to philosophy proper. It analyses anvitarthavāda, arthāpatti, anupalabdhi, the validity of knowledge, knownness (jñātatā), God's omniscience, eight grounds for establishing God, Vedic

injunction and motivating force, yogic perception, and the relationship between reasoning and faith. The chapter itself treats the controversies over connected meaning, postulation, non-apprehension and knownness as groundwork for the demonstration of God.

An important philosophical strength of the book becomes clear here: the argument for God does not begin abruptly in the fifth cluster. The first four clusters develop theories of causation, the means of knowledge, linguistic comprehension, absence, epistemic validity, knownness, the world and cognition, on which the positive inferences of the fifth can stand. To regard that last cluster merely as an isolated list of 'eight proofs of God' would therefore be to miss the architecture of the work.

In its response to anvitābhidhānavāda, the question whether words independently convey meaning and how their meanings combine within a sentence becomes self-referential for translation itself. Opposition to recognising arthāpatti and anupalabdhi as independent pramāṇas becomes a central point of disagreement between Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā.

The refutation of knownness is especially significant. If every instance of true cognition required 'novelty' or some externally established property of being known, the knowledge of an eternally omniscient God could become problematic. By removing this obstacle, the fourth cluster prepares the epistemological ground for the fifth.

The eight grounds for establishing God — kārya, āyojana, dhṛti, pada, pratyaya, śruti, vākya and saṃkhyā — form the philosophical culmination of the book. A positive feature of Chapter 6 is that it does not treat all eight as arguments of the same kind: some concern causation, some the combination of atoms, some linguistic signs, some the validity of cognition, and some Vedic sentences.

Caution is needed in employing modern comparisons. Terms such as 'cosmological argument', 'linguistic argument' and 'natural theology' provide useful bridges for readers, but the historical meaning of Udayana's arguments should not be wholly assimilated into categories derived from European philosophy of religion.

Research Chapter 7: Udayanācārya, the Commentary Tradition, and the Indian Debate on God

Research Chapter 7 encompasses a research introduction; Udayanācārya's life and Mithila's Nyāya tradition; the structure of the work; the number of stabhakas and kārikās; the five opposing contentions (vipratipattis); all five stabhakas; the tradition of commentaries and expositions; historical translations; Nārāyaṇa Śāstrī Drāviḍa's study; the work's influence on Navya-Nyāya; and a conclusion. The contents explicitly provide separate sections on the commentary tradition and Drāviḍa's research.

The chapter constructs a history of the work's reception. Its important academic achievement is to situate translation not merely as a present-day linguistic act, but within a succession of Sanskrit commentaries, modern editions, and translations.

Nevertheless, source citations in footnotes are indispensable for matters such as biography, chronology, the number of kārikās, and variations between editions. One passage in the book mentions alternative totals of seventy-two and seventy-three kārikās. A critical edition ought to explain why the totals differ, which edition follows which count, and which verses have been counted together or separately.

The value of Chapter 7 lies in its refusal to forget the long commentary tradition behind the Maithili translation, even while recognising that translation as an independent modern undertaking.

Research Chapter 8: An Integrated Philosophical, Linguistic, and Cultural Study

Research Chapter 8 offers a broad, integrated study of Nyāyakusumāñjali and its Maithili translation. It brings together the Navya-Nyāya background, the historical and social position of Maithili, the five opposing contentions, all five stabhakas, the eight reasons adduced for establishing God, the Nyāya–Mīmāṃsā disputes over the means of knowledge, the doctrine of connected meaning (anvitārthavāda), postulation (arthāpatti), non-apprehension (anupalabdhi), the linguistic and philosophical significance of translation, Indian literary theories, Western translation theory, the parallel literary movement, and digital transformation.

The chapter's conclusion treats Udayana's work not as a religious proclamation but as an inquiry into God founded on rigorous reasoning, epistemology, and debate. It sets out the eight grounds in sequence: kāryāt, āyojanāt, dhṛtyādeḥ, padāt, pratyayataḥ, śruteḥ, vākyāt, and saṃkhyāviśeṣāc ca.

The limitation of this chapter is repetition. Material examined separately and at length in Chapters 5–7 is revisited in an integrated reading in Chapter 8. If the book is organised as a research monograph, this chapter should be explicitly identified as an "overall synthesis"; otherwise readers may feel that the same subjects recur without explanation.

Research Chapter 9: The First Truly Comprehensive Review Based on All Five Clusters

Chapter 9 marks an exceptionally important turning point in the book. Here the study is explicitly founded on the complete text of all five stabhakas. The chapter itself observes that only after the entire work became available, from the opening invocation to the final offering of flowers, was it possible to examine the unbroken movement of argument, the pattern of metaphors, and the translation's linguistic policy from beginning to end.

Its map of the arguments is particularly successful: the first cluster addresses causality, adṛṣṭa, and the permanence of the self; the second, the validity of cognition, the impermanence of words, and creation and dissolution; the third, non-apprehension, the examination of the means of knowledge, and debate about verbal testimony; the fourth, true cognition and God's eternal knowledge; and the fifth, the proofs advanced for God and the concluding floral offering.

The chapter systematically examines the double meaning (śleṣa) of the invocation, the heroism of argument subordinated to śānta-rasa, figures of speech, propriety (aucitya), and oblique expression (vakrokti). Its Western approaches include reason-centred philosophical theology, Bakhtinian polyphony, Gadamer's fusion of horizons, Formalism, and New Criticism. In translation studies it considers Nida and Newmark, Venuti and Berman, and Skopos and Toury; in language and style, it addresses technical terminology and the resources of ordinary vocabulary.

The chapter's most significant scholarly virtue is methodological modesty. The parallel English section expressly states that the study is directed towards the target text—the Maithili translation—and does not undertake a line-by-line comparison with the Sanskrit original; it therefore cannot award a final certificate of word-level fidelity to the source. Internal coherence in the target text and fidelity to the source are recognised as two distinct criteria. This admission enhances the scholarly credibility of the volume as a whole.

Research Chapter 10: The Central Scholarly Achievement of the Complete Work

Chapter 10 is the best organised, most mature, and most academically useful part of this book. It is, in effect, a research monograph in its own right.

It incorporates the base text, a research statement, an abstract, keywords, methodology, historical and textual context, the metaphor of the "offering of flowers" (kusumāñjali), the five fundamental doubts, the arguments of all five clusters, the method of disputation, the examination of the means of knowledge, absence, postulation and non-apprehension, the self, atoms, adṛṣṭa, creation and dissolution, words, sentences, intention and injunction, the nature of God, fair presentation of opposing positions, Indian poetics, modern hermeneutics, comparative philosophy, translation method, language and style, editorial arrangement, twelve representative passages, the significance of the work in Maithili's knowledge tradition, conclusions, further research, and five appendices. This wide range of subjects is clearly laid out in the book.

The Philosophical Unity of All Five Clusters

The chief achievement of Chapter 10 is that it reads the five stabhakas not as five separate essays, but as an ascending journey of reasoning.

The first cluster begins with the problems of causality, the fruits of action, the self, and the doctrine of momentariness. The second examines the foundations of knowledge and tradition through the validity of cognition, the impermanence of words, and creation and dissolution. The third scrutinises inferences purporting to establish God's absence, the self-contradiction involved in rejecting inference, comparison, verbal testimony, connected verbal meaning, postulation, and non-apprehension. Through disputes over true cognition, memory, and knownness (jñātatā), the fourth safeguards the possibility of eternal omniscient knowledge. The fifth then offers affirmative inferences concerning God through effect, the initial conjunction of atoms,

sustaining power, words, cognition, Vedic revelation, sentences, and number. The book itself summarises the sequence in this way.

Chapter 10 makes this philosophical unity especially clear. Readers consequently understand that the culmination of Nyāyakusumāñjali is not simply the pronouncement "God exists," but the question of what kind of metaphysics is demanded by causation, knowledge, language, number, the means of knowledge, and the moral order.

Method of Reasoning

To present the opposing thesis (pūrvapakṣa) in its full force, demonstrate its consequences, identify a defect, assume a counterfactual situation and test its implications, and finally bring the argument to its own contradiction—Chapter 10 correctly captures this important feature of Udayana's method.

The Cārvāka rejection of inference is a particularly telling example: if every inference is unacceptable, how can the rejection of inference itself claim universal acceptance? This kind of practical self-contradiction is especially compelling for modern readers.

Absence and Non-apprehension

The chapter systematically examines subtle problems involving the counterpositive of an absence (pratiyogin), the character of non-apprehension (anupalabdhi), the inclusion of postulation (arthāpatti) within inference, and the rejection of non-apprehension as an independent means of knowledge. Simple contemporary language is helpful here; a parallel glossary of the original Sanskrit technical terms would, however, make the discussion still more useful to researchers.

Metaphysics

A particular strength of the discussion of the enduring self, adṛṣṭa and moral causality, atoms, and creation and dissolution is that the chapter warns against unjustified identification with modern science. Adṛṣṭa is explained not as an "unknown miracle" but as a causal link between action and its fruit; equating the ancient atomic doctrine with modern atomic physics is recognised as a historical mistake. This discrimination is commendable.

Philosophy of Language

Questions of words, sentences, intended meaning (tātparya), injunction, word meaning, sentence meaning, and authorship are directly connected with the book's translation project. The independent power of words to convey meaning, the role of intention, syntactic connection within sentences, and the motivating force of injunctions are not merely ancient Mīmāṃsā debates: they also underlie the translator's daily decisions.

Appendices

A thematic map of all five clusters, a concise glossary of fallacies, a selected terminology list, a questionnaire for researchers, and a policy for textual sources and quotation elevate Chapter 10 from ordinary criticism to a resource for university study. A future edition could expand these appendices and place them at the end of the book as shared research tools; doing so would greatly increase their usefulness.

Research Chapter II: The Complete Maithili Translation

This is the centre of the book. The first ten chapters construct a critical framework around this text, but the book's real historical value resides in Chapter II.

4. The Five Flower Clusters of the Complete Maithili Translation: An Unbroken Journey of Argument

The First Cluster of Flowers: Causality, Action, Causal Efficacy, the Self, and Momentariness

The first cluster opens with a verse of humility in the auspicious invocation. Thereafter come, in sequence, the object of inquiry; the need for inquiry; a proposition for examination; the possibility of origination "by chance" (akasmāt); the cause–effect relation; general and particular causes; the causal theories of Advaita and Sāṅkhya; invisible causes; causal efficacy (sāmarthya); causation through absence; the Mīmāṃsā theory of causal efficacy; produced or superimposed efficacy; the effect of sacrifice; impressions left in the agent; Nyāya's account of efficacy; Sāṅkhya; Cārvāka; universal momentariness; permanence and causation; and finally, prayer.

The cluster's fundamental questions are these: why is there regularity in the world and in experience? Can one escape causality merely by saying "by chance"? How do the fruits of action extend into the distant future? If the self is momentary, how are memory, latent impressions (saṃskāras), moral consequences, and the unity of experience possible?

The translation makes effective use of a question-and-answer style in presenting these difficult arguments. Maithili constructions such as "If we accept this, then…", "But an objection arises here…", and "The answer is…" lend the technical sequence of Nyāya reasoning the accessibility of an oral philosophical debate.

The decision to unfold the invocation's two meanings again deserves particular notice. By making clear the connections between the freshness, fragrance, and immortality of the flower and the authority of the doctrines of Nyāya, the translation preserves the richness of meaning produced by śleṣa, or punning double sense.

The Second Cluster of Flowers: The Validity of Cognition, the Impermanence of Words, Creation, and Dissolution

The second cluster begins with the grounds on which knowledge is valid. Whether the truth of genuine cognition is recognised through an external cause or is known intrinsically becomes the centre of disagreement between Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā. There follow the attempt to establish the impermanence of words, the transmission of words through tradition, utterance, common linguistic form, the teacher–pupil succession, creation and cosmic dissolution, the gradual decline of religious duty, conduct, and education, memory, Vedic injunctions no longer available, the interruption of tradition at dissolution, renewed creation, and a criticism of the view that sages such as Kapila initiate scripture by virtue of their omniscience. Noteworthy here is the distinction that, even though individual utterances are impermanent, a relation to meaning can persist through tradition.

This cluster moves from the first cluster's analysis of causation to epistemology and cosmology. The subject appears to change, but the connection is clear: if tradition is not an unbroken, beginningless continuum, the question arises how the order of knowledge can be re-established. That question leads further towards the proposed necessity of an omniscient governor.

Linguistically, this cluster is denser than the first. The long sentences in the examination of validity demand sustained attention. The earlier review itself suggests that selective division of sentences would be useful here.

The Third Cluster of Flowers: Atheistic Inferences, Cārvāka, Comparison, Verbal Testimony, Connected Meaning, Postulation, and Non-apprehension

The third cluster is the book's centre of epistemological inquiry. It brings together arguments that attempt to infer non-existence from the absence of knowledge of God; the counterpositive of negation; unreal entities; other inferences purporting to prove God's absence; the defence and refutation of those inferences; the Cārvāka attack on inference; Nyāya's justification of inference; comparison (upamāna); differences between Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya positions; Vaiśeṣika objections; verbal testimony (śabda-pramāṇa); Prabhākara's distinction between Vedic and everyday sentences; connected meaning; objections based on testimony to an omniscient creator; postulation (arthāpatti); and non-apprehension (anupalabdhi). The book sets out this sequence explicitly.

This cluster is among the translation's most difficult areas, because the fine distinctions among terms such as anupalabdhi (non-apprehension), pratiyogin (counterpositive), viśeṣya (qualificand), vyāpti (invariable concomitance), upamāna (comparison), and bodhaśakti (power to generate cognition) cannot be replaced by ordinary near-synonyms. The translator's policy of retaining the original terms while constructing explanatory Maithili sentences is the right one.

Instead of making the Cārvāka voice ridiculous, the work presents its argument at full strength. Consequently the response offered by the opposing side acquires intellectual credibility. From the standpoint of polyphony, this is one of the book's finest passages.

The Fourth Cluster of Flowers: True Cognition, Memory, and Knownness

The fourth cluster is relatively short, yet decisive in the architecture of the philosophy. Its principal sequence concerns the nature of cognition, the Mīmāṃsā position, the first proof offered in support of an objective property called "knownness" (jñātatā) and its refutation, followed by a second proof and its refutation.

Its significance should be understood as preparation for the fifth cluster. If the truth of cognition were necessarily dependent on novelty, knownness, or a property arising outside cognition after knowledge has occurred, difficulties would arise for God's eternal omniscience. The fourth cluster removes this obstacle. The book's overall analysis likewise makes clear that by rejecting knownness, the fourth cluster safeguards the validity of an omniscient being's eternal knowledge.

From the standpoint of translation, this passage is exceptionally dense. A future scholarly edition would reduce the reader's burden by giving concise definitions of pramā (true cognition), prāmāṇya (validity), jñātatā (knownness), viṣayatā (objecthood or being-an-object-of-cognition), and smṛti (memory) alongside their first occurrences.

The Fifth Cluster of Flowers: Eight Grounds for Establishing God and the Devotional Culmination of Argument

The fifth cluster is the climax of the entire work. Arguments establishing God's existence are presented and defended; objections receive replies; the internal contradictions of conditional counterarguments advanced by atheists are exposed. The discussion moves through the need for a conscious cause of the first motion of atoms,

the sustenance of the universe, words, cognition, revelation, sentences, numbers, injunctions, commands, verbal action, effort, the connection between acts and their fruits, scriptural utterances, the naming of Vedic branches, yogic perception, and scriptural support for the perception of God.

The eight celebrated grounds—kārya, āyojana, dhṛti, pada, pratyaya, śruti, vākya, and saṃkhyā—are the crowning jewels of the work. It would nevertheless be inappropriate to call them eight independent "scientific proofs" in the modern sense. They are interconnected groups of inferences fashioned within Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika metaphysics, the philosophy of language, epistemology, and the Vedic tradition.

The verse gathering these eight grounds together is: "कार्यायोजनधृत्यादेः पदात् प्रत्ययतः श्रुतेः। वाक्यात् संख्याविशेषाच्च साध्यो विश्वविदव्ययः॥" In other words, through eight routes—being an effect, the conjunction or arrangement of atoms, sustenance and dissolution, words, cognition, revelation, sentences, and particular numerical structure—the existence of the imperishable knower of the universe, the omniscient God, is established.

(1) Kāryāt, from effect: The world is a produced entity, an effect (kārya). Just as a pot is made by a potter, so the world must have an omniscient maker. Udayanācārya rejects the atheist's objection that an agent must possess a body, identifying bodily existence as an upādhi, an unwarranted additional condition: being an effect is a general property, whereas embodiment is a particular property, and God's eternal knowledge and will make agency without a body possible. (2) Āyojanāt, from the initial arrangement: The first motion of atoms—on the argument that the motion of insentient things requires conscious prompting—requires an intelligent, omniscient initiator. (3) Dhṛtyādeḥ, from sustenance and related processes: The maintenance of the cosmos (a divine sustaining effort conceived as underlying natural laws such as gravity), and the process of destruction at the great dissolution, require a conscious agent. (4) Padāt, from words: The original establishment of linguistic conventions, particularly the teaching of language to new beings at the beginning of each cycle of creation, requires a primordial teacher. (5) Pratyayataḥ, from cognition or trustworthiness: The authority of the Veda establishes the freedom from defects of its speaker; consequently a speaker possessed of perfect knowledge is required. (6) Śruteḥ, from revelation: The Veda consists of collections of sentences, and every such collection must have a composer; only an omniscient God can truly describe supersensible realities. (7) Vākyāt, from sentences: The intended meaning of Vedic sentences depends upon a speaker's purpose, and the meaningfulness of first-person pronouns employed in the Veda demands an independent speaker. (8) Saṃkhyāviśeṣāc ca, from numerical particularity: Explaining the magnitude of dyads and triads formed from atoms requires a counting consciousness (apekṣā-buddhi), possible at the beginning of creation, when no living beings existed, only in an omniscient God. The fifth cluster concludes with the philosophical nature of Vedic commands and injunctions, the possibility of yogic perception, and prayer to God.

The sequence of these eight proofs is itself a logical architecture: cosmological (cause and effect), kinetic (motion), physical and cosmological (sustenance and dissolution), linguistic (signs and words), epistemic (cognition), scriptural (the authority of revelation), semantic (sentence meaning), and numerical or atomic (number and combination). Eight distinct lines of inquiry converge on one conclusion, demonstrating the many-sided range of Udayanācārya's logical imagination.

A special achievement of the translation is the separate section devoted to the "alternative meanings of the terms used for the grounds in the original text." Just as the several meanings of the invocation were disclosed separately, the final cluster also preserves a second layer of meaning in the source terms. The book regards this as an instance of "layered fidelity."

At the end, reasoning is transformed into devotion. The author wishes the fragrance of these flowers of reasoning to reach believers and non-believers alike; finally, the intellectual floral offering is dedicated to God. The parallel English text likewise ends with this conclusion: a prayer for sound understanding for the atheist, the mind immersed in the Lord, and the flower metaphor of the five clusters.

In this final movement, the literary character of Nyāyakusumāñjali becomes most apparent: argument does not annihilate itself but, turning into a flower, becomes an offering.

5. A Focused Philosophical Examination: Knowledge, Sound, Causality, Dissolution, Karma, and Tradition

The Indian philosophical tradition is extraordinarily rich and many-sided. For millennia it has sustained profound debates on existence, knowledge, and the means of attaining liberation. Within this intellectual churning, Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika philosophy occupies a pre-eminent position and is renowned internationally for its logical realism and atomic pluralism. Nyāya is principally concerned with the theory of the means of valid knowledge (epistemology), while its allied system, Vaiśeṣika, undertakes a minute analysis of the objects of knowledge (ontology). The ultimate aim of both systems is complete release from worldly suffering—that is, *mokṣa*—which becomes possible through true knowledge. The *Nyāyakusumāñjali*, composed by the great philosopher Udayanācārya in the tenth century, is an enduring work that offers extensive logical explanations of God's existence, the validity of knowledge, cause-and-effect relations, and the physical laws of creation. This work of Udayanācārya is not merely a foundational text of Nyāya philosophy; it also mounts a vigorous refutation of non-theistic positions, including Buddhist philosophy.

5.1 The Theoretical Background of Epistemology and the Means of Knowledge

How cognition arises, what its nature is, and how its validity is determined constitute an exceptionally complex and fundamental question of Indian philosophy. Nyāya, which treats cognition as an illuminating factor distinct from both its object and its subject, upholds realism. Where Advaita Vedānta stresses the ultimate or metaphysical nature of knowledge, Nyāya gives sustained attention to its practical and logical character.

According to Nyāya, knowledge or *pramiti* is an apprehension of reality, called *pramā*. Cognition that does not correspond to reality is *apramā* (invalid knowledge). Nyāya describes a particular psychological and logical process through which cognition is produced. Direct awareness of an external object is impossible unless the senses are connected with the mind (*manas*) and the mind, in turn, is connected with the self (*ātman*). Thus, sense–object contact presupposes both mind–sense contact and self–mind contact. Here the mind functions as the mediator between the self and the senses.

5.2 Prāmāṇyavāda: The Philosophical Conflict over the Truth of Cognition

Philosophical school	Principal doctrine	Accepted means of valid knowledge
Nyāya philosophy (classical)	Logical realism	Perception, inference, verbal testimony
Navya-Nyāya (Udayanācārya and others)	The New Logic	Perception, inference, verbal testimony, comparison (four pramāṇas)
Vaiśeṣika philosophy	Atomic pluralism	Perception, inference (two pramāṇas)

The theory of *prāmāṇya*—the validity of knowledge—has generated a major debate within Indian epistemology. Its two principal positions are *svataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda* (intrinsic validity), upheld by Advaita Vedānta and Mīmāṃsā, and *parataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda* (extrinsic validity), defended by Nyāya.

Intrinsic Validity versus Extrinsic Validity

According to Advaita Vedānta and Mīmāṃsā, cognition establishes its own truth: when knowledge occurs, it is originally valid unless an external defeating factor

subsequently proves it false. This is the doctrine of intrinsic validity. By contrast, Nyāya's doctrine of extrinsic validity holds that neither a cognition's validity nor the awareness of that validity follows simply from the causes that produced the cognition itself; rather, they depend on external conditions and causes.

Nyāya rejects the proposition that cognition is true by its very nature. Its argument is that validity consists in correspondence with the object: to know a thing as it actually is constitutes true cognition. Novelty, production through the senses, or apprehension of something previously unknown are not necessary conditions of truth. The ultimate criterion of truth is grounded in causal relations. To establish a cognition's truth, Nyāya relies on inference. Here the principal *hetu*, or middle term, is its "being the cause of successful practical activity." That is, if a cognition leads someone to act towards an object and that action succeeds, the cognition is regarded as true.

The Fault of Mutual Dependence and the Psychological Mechanism of Memory and Impressions

If the validity of cognition is inferred from its "causing successful action," a serious logical difficulty arises: *anyonyāśraya-doṣa*, the fault of circularity or mutual dependence. The opponent argues that the *sādhya* (what is to be established, namely the cognition's validity) and the *hetu* (its causal connection with successful activity) become identical, because the success of the action itself depends on the truth of the cognition. In other words, validity is being proved through a middle term whose status as a middle term already presupposes validity.

To avoid this fault, Nyāya proposes a subtle psychological and logical account. "Being a cause of successful activity" is not a generic property shared indiscriminately by a class. Each instance of true cognition is the particular cause of its own corresponding successful action, and it is through this individual causal relation that the cognition's truth is inferred. Yet there is a practical difficulty: by the time the outcome of the action—its success—has occurred, the original cognition, which is momentary, has ceased to exist. How, then, can its causal connection with the action be known?

The answer lies in the psychological mechanism of *smṛti* (memory) and *saṃskāra* (mental impression). Although the original cognition has passed away, it has left an impression, a memorial trace, in consciousness. When the action succeeds, that impression reawakens the memory of the original cognition. Through this recollection, the person recognises: "That cognition was the cause of the successful activity."

The theory is explained through the example of "earthhood" and smell. If one wishes to establish that a particular thing belongs to the material category of earth, one first experiences its distinctive property, smell. An impression of previously experienced objects then awakens a memory through which the present object is recognised as sharing the earthhood associated with smell. It should be noted that recognition (*pratyabhijñā*) or memory is not simply a mixture of two cognitions of entirely different kinds. In the judgement "This is the same pot that I saw earlier," present perception and past recollection converge in a single mental conclusion, although each arises under distinct causal conditions. It is through additional conditions, such as present cognition or an existing impression, that awareness of the self becomes perceptual or recollective in character.

A principal Nyāya argument against intrinsic validity is that doubts about the truth of cognition repeatedly arise. Yet Nyāya also maintains that doubting the validity of every

instance of self-awareness would be self-defeating. If no awareness of the self is true, then the occurrence of doubt itself cannot be known as true. If doubt is accepted as real, the validity of the awareness through which doubt is known must also be admitted. The argument presents a substantial challenge to philosophical positions such as Advaita Vedānta.

5.3 Nyāya's Procedure of Inference

Point of comparison	Intrinsic validity (Advaita/Mīmāṃsā)	Extrinsic validity (Nyāya)
Ground of a cognition's truth	Inherent in the cognition's own nature	Depends on external conditions and successful practical activity
Status of doubt	Cognition is intrinsically free of doubt; a defeating factor arises afterwards	Doubt is possible and must be resolved through inference
Theory of causation	No external cause is required for truth	Causal connection is established through memory and mental impressions

The five-membered inference (*pañcāvayava*) presented by Nyāya for establishing the truth of a proposition is the backbone of Indian logic. Its five members are: (1) *pratijñā* (proposition)—for example, "This hill possesses fire" (*parvato vahnimān*); (2) *hetu* (reason)—"Because there is smoke there" (*dhūmāt*); (3) *udāharaṇa* (example)—"Wherever there is smoke, there is fire, as in a kitchen hearth" (*yatra yatra dhūmaḥ, tatra tatra vahniḥ*); (4) *upanaya* (application)—"This hill is of that kind too" (*tathā cāsau*); and (5) *nigamana* (conclusion)—"Therefore this hill possesses fire" (*tasmāt tathā*).

Upon this fine-grained logical framework, Nyāya constructs its explanations of God, the truth of knowledge, and the phenomenal world. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, regarded as the founder of Navya-Nyāya (the New Logic), developed this logical system to an exceptionally high level in his *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, profoundly influenced by the principles of the *Nyāyakusumāñjali*.

5.4 Words and the Physics of Sound

In the Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika tradition, physics and ontology are closely connected. An analysis of the production of words and sound is not merely a matter of physics; it is also required for the refutation of the Mīmāṃsā doctrine of *jātiśaktivāda*. Mīmāṃsā thinkers hold that words and universals (*jāti*) are eternal and possess an everlasting power to express meaning. They argue that while causes of the destruction of impermanent objects are observable, no corresponding cause is seen for the destruction of a word; words must therefore be eternal. Nyāya, however, rejects this position completely.

The Relationship between Ākāśa, Vibration, and Sound

For Nyāya philosophers, sound is impermanent and is a quality of *ākāśa* (space or ether). A musical instrument—such as a vīṇā, a flute, or a mṛdaṅga—is not itself the substrate in which sound inheres. In ordinary speech we say that "the vīṇā or flute is sounding" or that "the instrument possesses sound." Philosophically speaking, however, the instrument is only the source of the activity, or vibration, which produces sound. The instrument is the efficient cause; *ākāśa* is its inherent cause, or the actual locus in which sound resides.

When a person cannot hear a sound from a distance, this does not mean that sound is all-pervasive and merely goes unheard. It means either that some obstructing factor intervenes between the auditory faculty and the complex of causes producing sound, or that the auditory faculty has a defect. The equation "not heard = not existent" is not a universal rule; the case must instead be understood through differences in the relevant causal conditions.

The Logical Distinction between the "Destruction" and the "Absolute Absence" of Sound

When a musical instrument stops being played, its sound comes to an end. A Mīmāṃsā philosopher might ask what happens to that sound once the instrument stops. Does it merely become dormant forever? Nyāya argues that if sound did not perish but only became inaudible, then even after instruments fell silent, an unlimited accumulation of old sounds would have to be admitted as existing somewhere in *ākāśa*—for which there is no evidence.

Here Nyāya makes a clear distinction between *dhvaṃsa* (destruction or subsequent absence) and *atyantābhāva* (absolute non-existence). Absolute absence has no temporal limit; it always obtains in its locus, as with the absolute absence of form or colour in *ākāśa*. But when an instrument falls silent, the absence that arises is *dhvaṃsa*, or *pradhvaṃsābhāva*: something existed before and has now ceased to exist. If absolute absence of sound in the instrument were established, the destruction of the sound that has just ceased could not be established there, and the inference would incur the fault of *sādhyābhāva*—the absence of what was to be proved.

Moreover, the destruction of a thing occurs in the place where that thing actually inheres. Since *ākāśa*, not the instrument, is the locus of sound, the destruction of sound also takes place in *ākāśa*. The cessation of vibration, through the cause-and-effect relation, establishes the consequent absence of sound.

This philosophical analysis also enters into dialogue with conceptions of sound in Yoga and other Tantric traditions. In Yoga philosophy, Patañjali regards *oṃkāra* (*praṇava*) as a universal symbol or a ground—a norm or matrix—of all kinds of sounds; meditation upon it leads to *samādhi*. Certain Vedic traditions have even attributed therapeutic effects to sound vibrations and mental power, including hypnosis. Nyāya, by contrast, analyses sound simply as a physical quality subject to causal relations.

5.5 Metaphysics and Cosmology: The Principle of Causation and Atomism

Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika is an uncompromisingly realist philosophy and holds that every transformation in the world is governed by the law of causality. It strongly endorses atomism, treating eternal atoms as the fundamental material causes (*upādāna-kāraṇa*) of the universe.

Atoms, Composite Wholes, and Contingent Causation

According to Nyāya, every effect or produced thing arises from the presence of a particular complex of causes and ceases when that complex is absent. Where the cause is present, the effect arises; where the cause is absent, the effect is absent. This is presented as a general law of the world.

Nyāya rejects the opponent's claim that the production or destruction of an effect depends only on human purposes and experiences. Its example is breathing during sleep: a sleeping person is not conscious of the usefulness of breathing, yet breathing

continues. The physical laws of causation therefore continue to operate in the universe even in the absence of conscious utility or awareness.

If the productive causes were eternal and always active in exactly the same way, their effects would also be eternal, and the appearance of those effects at particular times would be impossible. Yet the created world is subject to change. From dyads (*dvyaṇukas*, paired atoms) and the smallest living things to the vast universe, all exist within causal relations. We must therefore acknowledge that the conjunction and separation of the relevant complexes of causes are contingent rather than eternal. The atoms (*paramāṇu*) are eternal, but the composite wholes (*avayavins*) constituted by their conjunctions are wholly impermanent and destructible.

Cosmic Dissolution (Pralaya) and Inescapable Destruction

When the universe completes its cycle of existence, the entire cosmos dissolves back into an atomic state. In this philosophy, that final condition is called *pralaya*, or dissolution. During *pralaya*, all atoms become separated from one another, and the created world comes completely to an end. The atoms themselves are not destroyed in the process; only their conjunctions are broken.

Nyāya's forceful argument is this: once the basic constituents—the atoms—have become disjoined, how could any living or non-living thing survive in its composite form? Such wholes must inevitably disintegrate. To elucidate this inescapable destruction, the *Nyāyakusumāñjali* provides three exceptionally precise and practical examples.

These examples are presented as decisively establishing that, when an appropriate destructive cause is present, a composite world cannot remain intact after the dissolution of the constituents on which it depends.

Illustration	Destructive cause	Consequence
Udumbara fruit and flies	An enraged monkey eats the fruit that serves as their abode	The flies inside the fruit are inevitably destroyed
Insects in a hollow tree	A fierce fire engulfs the tree	The insects are reduced to ashes along with the tree
Passengers gathered on a ship	A conflagration in the sea at the time of cosmic dissolution	All the passengers perish together with the ship

The Logical Establishment of God's Existence

For Nyāya, the entire chain of reasoning concerning cosmic dissolution and the destruction of composite wholes is more than a physical explanation: it is also a major foundation for establishing God's existence through a teleological argument. If all atoms have become completely separated after dissolution, how will "initial motion," dyadic combination, and conjunction arise among them in the subsequent creation? Insentient, inert atoms cannot initiate motion of their own accord.

Udayanācārya therefore argues for the necessity of a conscious agent called God. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, too, elaborates this question in the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, explaining that the earth and material objects are effects and must therefore possess a conscious cause, God. The conjunction and disjunction of unconscious atoms cannot occur without a conscious regulator. This line of reasoning bears a deep philosophical resemblance to Western arguments from an "Unmoved Mover" or a "First Cause."

5.6 The Theory of Karma, Saṃskāra, and the Gradual Decline of Human Traditions

Moving beyond the physical world of atoms, Nyāya also offers a subtle account of the operations of the psychological and moral world. If all composite things perish at the time of *pralaya*, what gives the next creation its form and diversity? The answer is *adṛṣṭa* (the unseen force), or the fruits of karma.

Karma, Experience, and Continuity

All experiences of pleasure and suffering arise from the accumulated fruits of a living being's previous actions. Although a person's experiences result from karma, this does not annul the natural physical causal relations among objects. In agreement with the Buddhist idea of karmic continuity and Vedāntic conceptions of *saṃskāra*, Nyāya also holds that impressions and deeds from a person's previous birth remain present within the self as *adṛṣṭa*, even after cosmic dissolution. On the basis of these impressions, the kinds of experiences allotted to living beings in the next creation are determined. Karma is thus a trans-worldly law that makes individuals responsible for their actions and sustains the cycle of birth and death.

The Decline of Tradition and Conduct across the Ages

The *Nyāyakusumāñjali* discusses not only the physical dissolution of the cosmos but also presents a profound sociological and philosophical picture of the gradual deterioration of human social and cultural traditions. As time passes through successive ages, birth customs, sacraments, education, dedication to study, and the performance of duties progressively weaken.

The most striking example offered is the deterioration of procreation and the customs surrounding birth:

The effects of this deterioration are said to extend beyond the process of birth to the rites of conception and birth themselves. In earlier times, the food consumed by a pregnant woman was purified through mantras and ritual observances. Subsequently, the rites came to be performed upon the pregnant woman herself rather than upon her food; ultimately, only a rite directed towards the foetus developing in the womb remained prescribed.

Stage or age	Process of procreation	Characteristic disposition
First stage (ancient times)	Children arise through mental resolve alone	Pure willpower and the highest development of consciousness
Second stage	Sexual union undertaken by parents solely for the pure purpose of having a child	Duty-motivated conduct in accordance with dharma
Third stage	Obligatory cohabitation of husband and wife impelled by sexual desire	Physical attraction predominates, but within marital bounds
Fourth stage (present times)	Unrestrained and wanton intercourse between women and men, likened to animal behaviour	Complete erosion of place, time, and propriety; animalistic tendencies

This account suggests that, just as the physical world shows a tendency to move from order towards disorder, a corresponding decline of consciousness occurs in the social and moral world. The fall from a purely mental plane to an entirely physical or animal plane is taken as evidence that the tighter the bonds of karma become, the more the living being moves towards inert materiality.

5.7 Interrelations with Other Philosophical Traditions

These propositions of Nyāya did not develop in an intellectual vacuum. They emerged as serious responses and counterarguments to the doctrines of Advaita Vedānta, Viśiṣṭādvaita, Mīmāṃsā, and Buddhist philosophy.

Opposition to Advaita Vedānta and Buddhism

Advaita Vedānta, associated with Śaṅkarācārya, holds that Brahman alone is ultimately real and that the entire world, individual beings, and *māyā* are its apparent manifestation (*vivarta*). For Vedānta, the triad of knower, cognition, and known object is real only at the empirical level; at the ultimate level it dissolves into non-duality. Nyāya, by contrast, is thoroughly realist: the knower (self), cognition (*pramiti*), and known object are fully distinct and real entities. The Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika world is neither illusory nor *māyā*, but an actual conjunction of atoms. Nevertheless, Nyāya and Vedānta agree that ignorance brings bondage and that true knowledge leads to liberation (*apavarga*).

Udayanācārya and other Nyāya philosophers, on the other hand, severely criticise Buddhist thinkers. Buddhism rejects the authority of the Vedas, and is in this sense classified as a non-Vedic (*nāstika*) philosophical system; it does not accept an eternal self, advancing instead the doctrine of non-self. In his *Nyāyakusumāñjali* and *Ātmatattvaviveka*, Udayanācārya offers logical refutations of Buddhist momentariness and non-theism, and is even said to have called Buddhist thinkers "deluded" because he regarded them as detractors of revealed Vedic testimony (*śruti*).

The Perspective of Viśiṣṭādvaita Vedānta and Its Synthesis

Viśiṣṭādvaita philosophy, developed by Rāmānujācārya and the later thinker Vedānta Deśika, makes critical use of many logical principles of Nyāya. In his celebrated *Nyāya-siddhāñjana*, Vedānta Deśika interprets the objects of valid knowledge (*prameyas*) discussed in Nyāya in the light of Viśiṣṭādvaita's relation between the body and the indwelling self (*śarīra–śarīri-bhāva*).

Unlike the Nyāya account, Viśiṣṭādvaita does not regard God merely as an efficient cause or logical agent. Rāmānuja considers God the indwelling ruler of everything and nature to be God's "body." Regarding cosmic dissolution, Viśiṣṭādvaita likewise holds that the insentient constituents of nature and conscious beings are absorbed into a subtle condition within God—an idea somewhat different from Nyāya's atomic disintegration, though conceptually parallel to it. In the *Nyāya-siddhāñjana*, Deśika explains that the arising and ceasing of sound in the five elements concerns the cessation of sense activity rather than the intrinsic form of phonemes, a position consonant with Rāmānuja's doctrines.

6. Assessment in the Light of Indian Literary Theory

Śleṣa and Vakrokti: The Artistry of the Auspicious Invocation

In the supplicatory verse of the maṅgalācaraṇa, words bearing two meanings (śleṣa) compare the principles of Nyāya philosophy with flowers: the word stabaka means both a "cluster of flowers" and a "chapter of a book." This double meaning is not merely linguistic play. In the sense given by Kuntaka's theory in the Vakroktijīvita, it is an outstanding example of vaidagdhya-bhaṅgī-bhaṇiti—expression distinguished by an artful turn—in which the rigour of logic and the delicacy of poetry coexist. Preserving this double field of signification in Maithili, where even the title has two meanings, posed a genuine challenge to the translator, who has addressed it with explanatory notes.

The Rasas: Wonder and Heroism Within the Primacy of Tranquillity

According to the Kāvyaprakāśa, śānta-rasa is the governing rasa (aṅgī) in a work chiefly concerned with philosophy; this is also the case in the Nyāyakusumāñjali. The delight of victory in argument occasionally permits vīra-rasa to appear, as at the decisive refutation of a non-theistic position; descriptions of the grandeur of cosmic creation, including the creation of the world from atoms, evoke adbhuta-rasa. Both function as subsidiary elements of the governing tranquillity. Devotional feeling becomes strong in the auspicious invocation, in references to release from suffering, and in the account of liberation, thereby reinforcing the devotional branch of śānta-rasa. The translation attempts, as far as possible, to preserve this affective dimension, especially in the invocation and the prayers closing the stabhakas. A delicate touch of karuṇa, prompted by concern for human suffering, further enlarges the work's structure of feeling.

Dhvani Theory: An Offering of Reason Beyond the Literal Meaning

From the standpoint of Ānandavardhana's theory of dhvani, the title and auspicious invocation are especially significant. The metaphor of the "cluster of flowers" (stabaka) does more than divide the book into structural units: through the power of suggestion (vyañjanā) it intimates that reasoning itself is a form of worship, and that a victory of logic is like a flower offered at God's feet. A philosophical resonance thus arises: beyond the literal presentation of arguments (vācyārtha), the suggested meaning (vyaṅgyārtha) of devotion and surrender resounds. The floral metaphor marks a movement from reasoning towards devotion; by the conclusion, argument itself merges into prayer.

Vakrokti and Figures of Speech

The translation makes appropriate use of simile—for example, the illustration of the spade-worker and the potter and pot—metaphor, above all the central image of the floral cluster, and irony, particularly the ironic tone that exposes the self-contradictions of non-theistic positions. Illustrative reasoning, such as inferring fire from smoke, makes abstract Nyāya arguments concrete and comprehensible; this is an aesthetic dimension of inference itself.

The Principle of Aucitya: Kṣemendra's Criterion

Judged by the criterion developed in Kṣemendra's Aucityavicāracarcā, the translation generally achieves a fitting relationship among subject, language, and audience. Its prose rhythm suits philosophical gravity; its technical terminology remains Sanskritic; and its illustrations are accessible through familiar experience. Together these

elements display an appropriate balance between Sanskrit-derived learned vocabulary and vernacular Maithili. At certain points, however, terminological severity—such as in the discussions of the causality of absence—burdens the general reader. This marks a limit of its contextual propriety.

Rīti and Guṇa

The translation's chief quality is prasāda: clarity and ease of understanding, particularly in its analogies and illustrations. Its refutational passages display ojas, an energetic force conveyed through firm, relatively uncompounded sentences and sharp logical thrusts. The auspicious invocation, floral imagery, and descriptions of liberation foreground mādhurya, or sweetness. A balance among these three qualities corresponds to the work's threefold character: reasoning, refutation, and devotion. In rhythm and linguistic manner it approaches the Vaidarbhī style, although some densely argumentative passages also suggest the compound-heavy intensity of Gauḍī rīti.

7. In the Light of Western Literary and Interpretive Theories

A methodological caution is essential: these modern theories should be employed as instruments of interpretation available to present-day readers, not treated as historical sources of Udayanācārya's thought.

Aristotelian Rhetoric and Intellectual Drama

Viewed through Aristotle's Rhetoric, the book's structure of pūrvapakṣa and uttarapakṣa takes the form of a classical dialectical demonstration in which three appeals work together: logos (reason), ethos (the authority of the learned speaker), and pathos (devotional feeling).

Russian Formalism and Defamiliarisation

Shklovsky's concept of ostranenie, or defamiliarisation, applies when Udayanācārya uses familiar illustrations—the pot and potter, or the worker with a spade—to disclose unfamiliar metaphysical truths from a fresh angle. Everyday objects acquire new meanings by becoming instruments of philosophical argument.

New Criticism and Internal Unity

From the standpoint of New Critical close reading, an organic relationship can be discerned among the title, invocation, and arguments. The "flower" is not merely an ornament but the central image of the work's organic unity, pervading it from the auspicious opening to its final prayer.

Structuralism and Binary Oppositions

From a structuralist perspective, the work is organised through binary oppositions such as theistic/non-theistic, conscious/inert, eternal/non-eternal, and effect/cause. These oppositions reappear in new forms in each stabaka and ultimately converge, in the fifth stabaka, upon a higher synthesis: an omniscient God.

Bakhtinian Dialogism: The Many Voices of Philosophical Debate

Bakhtin's concepts of polyphony and dialogism offer a natural interpretive framework for the tradition of śāstrārtha. Within the same text, Naiyāyikas, Mīmāṃsakas, Cārvākas, Buddhists, Sāṃkhyas, and Vaiśeṣikas engage one another. No voice is simply

suppressed: every opposing position is first presented in a sufficiently fair and complete form, and only then refuted. This plurality of voices is retained in the translation.

Hermeneutics: Schleiermacher, Gadamer, and the Fusion of Horizons

According to Gadamer's concept of the "fusion of horizons," translation builds a bridge between two horizons: the Sanskrit horizon of Udayanācārya in the eleventh century and that of the contemporary Maithili reader. In Schleiermacher's distinction between taking the reader towards the writer and bringing the writer towards the reader, this translation follows a balanced course: it neither wholly foreignises nor wholly domesticates its source.

Reader-Response Theory: Iser's Gaps

In terms of Wolfgang Iser's theory of gaps (Leerstellen), the title "An Offering of Flowers" is itself a space that the reader fills through interpretation. Are these flowers those of reasoning, of devotion, or of both? The translator deliberately preserves this ambiguity, thereby increasing the reader's involvement.

Deconstruction: Possibilities and Limits

Read through Derrida, the work's concept of upādhi—an unwarranted condition—can itself operate as an instrument of deconstruction. It shows how a non-theistic argument may depend excessively upon foundational categories, such as embodiment, and how the argument collapses when that condition is removed. Nevertheless, the work's ultimate objective, establishing the existence of God, is itself a foundationalist project. A deconstructive reading can therefore be applied only partially; that limitation must be acknowledged.

8. Evaluation in the Light of Modern Translation Theory

On Eugene Nida's scale of formal versus dynamic equivalence, the translation largely inclines towards dynamic equivalence, giving priority to the reader's comprehension while also preserving formal fidelity in technical terms. Within Peter Newmark's distinction between semantic and communicative translation, it seeks a balance: semantic precision governs philosophical terminology, while communicative accessibility governs the explanation of examples. From the standpoint of Vermeer's Skopos theory, which treats purpose as decisive in translation, the translator's clearly stated aim—to enable Maithili readers to participate in classical philosophical debate—justifies the choices made throughout the work.

In Lawrence Venuti's opposition between domestication and foreignisation, this translation takes a partly foreignising route. Sanskrit technical expressions such as adṛṣṭa, upādhi, abhāva, and prāmāṇya are retained in respect for the classical source culture's otherness. Yet its sentence construction and presentation of examples also involve domestication, showing a conscious caution against what Antoine Berman calls "deforming tendencies." In Catford's account of translation shifts, the conversion of kārikā verses into prose is a category shift—more specifically, a structure shift—which relaxes the poetic constraints of the original in favour of conceptual clarity. By Gideon Toury's criteria of acceptability and adequacy, the translation leans more towards acceptability: natural target-language norms in Maithili take precedence over strictly formal fidelity to the source-language structures. In the light of André Lefevere's rewriting theory and polysystem theory, the translation establishes within the Maithili literary polysystem a new subsystem of classical philosophical prose, corresponding to the Videha tradition's debates over parallel literary

institutions. George Steiner's fourfold "hermeneutic motion" in After Babel—trust, aggression, incorporation, and restitution—is also discernible here: trust in the original text; the probing, intellectually forceful extraction of meaning; its incorporation into Maithili prose; and, finally, the restitution of philosophical balance.

9. Translation Method, Terminology, Style, and Maithili Intellectual Prose

9.1 Not Literal Translation, but Explanatory Scholarly Translation

To describe this work as a literal translation would be to misunderstand its character. Original kārikā verses, the author's own prose, philosophical suggestions, the relationship between earlier and later stages of an argument, and the needs of the modern reader together produce an expanded Maithili version. The book itself rightly favours describing this process as "explanatory scholarly translation."

The advantages of this method are clear: the text becomes readable, stages in an argument become visible, and headings serve as maps through the maze of scholastic discussion. Its disadvantage is that the boundaries among the original, its author's commentary, the translator's explanations, and editorial notes can sometimes become blurred.

A critical edition should therefore clearly distinguish four layers: the original Sanskrit; a close Maithili translation; fluent explanatory Maithili; and editorial commentary. The book's own criticism acknowledges the need for precisely such a separation.

9.2 Navya-Nyāya Terminology and Lexical Policy

The Nyāyakusumāñjali stands at the point of transition from earlier Nyāya to Navya-Nyāya. Its translation appropriately brings into Maithili a vocabulary associated with that transition: abhāva, pratiyogin, upādhi, vyāpti, apekṣā-buddhi, jñātatā, anvitārtha, and abhihitānvaya, among other terms. When explaining a technical expression such as upādhi, the translator also gives a modern logical equivalent ("unwarranted condition") in parentheses, building a bridge between classical and modern logic. Read in terms of the intellectual continuity from Udayana to Gaṅgeśa, the translation adequately exposes the seeds of three central Navya-Nyāya concerns: the analysis of upādhi, the causal status of absence, and the debate between anvitābhidhānavāda and abhihitānvayavāda. The absence of a dedicated technical glossary and comparative table nevertheless remains a limitation for researchers.

The translator's most appropriate decision has been not to replace original Nyāya technical terms forcibly with everyday Maithili synonyms. Hetu, sādhya, vyāpti, upādhi, samavāya, pratiyogin, prāmāṇya, upamāna, śabda-pramāṇa, and abhāva have historically developed definitions. Replacing them might produce simplicity, but philosophical precision would be lost.

Maithili sentence structures have instead been constructed around these terms. The book regards this achievement as the creation of a modern Maithili intellectual prose capable of handling complex objections, alternatives, hetu, sādhya, vyāpti, upādhi, absence, valid means of knowledge, and theories of verbal meaning.

9.3 Vernacular Vocabulary and the System of Headings

Expressions such as "the horn of a hare," "the bumblebee," and "a cowshed in the Ganges" keep the translation alive. They represent more than domestication; they give philosophical abstractions a visible grounding in local experience.

Placing a clear Maithili heading before each complex argument is one of the translation's major editorial accomplishments. Modern readers could easily lose their way in the continuous web of prose and verse of the scholastic original; the headings indicate the direction of the reasoning. The comprehensive study also identifies this heading-marked progression of prose as a major achievement.

9.4 Long Sentences, Readability, and the Intended Audience

Some passages dealing with validity, connected meaning, jñātatā, and inference contain sentences loaded with subordinate clauses. This is not solely a failing of the translator: scholastic reasoning itself has this character. Nevertheless, selective division of long sentences at the editorial stage would improve readability, provided the boundaries of the conclusions remained intact.

In terms of Maithili syntax, the translation is generally natural, although certain long Sanskritic compounds leave traces of translationese. Its policy of retaining Sanskrit tatsama words in technical contexts is a considered decision, preserving scholastic gravity but sometimes making the text difficult for general readers. Clarity and judicious repetition, particularly through headings and question-and-answer presentation, help guide the reader. In tone, the translation maintains the decorum of respectful debate: its presentation of opposing schools contains no contemptuous mockery, in keeping with the propriety of śāstrārtha. As regards readability and audience, it is primarily directed towards highly educated readers interested in philosophy; general readers will need additional supporting material.

9.5 The Ethics of Presenting Opposing Arguments

One demanding test of a philosophical translation is whether it presents an opponent's argument fairly or weakens it so that it may be refuted with ease. By this standard the book succeeds. Cārvāka materialism, Buddhist momentariness, Sāṃkhya theories of causation, Kumārila's and Prabhākara's Mīmāṃsā, and Vaiśeṣika objections all receive sufficient intellectual respect.

This is not merely literary polyphony but philosophical fairness. The translator's voice may emerge victorious at points, but it does not turn the opponent into a buffoon.

9.6 The Historical Importance of Maithili Philosophical Prose

The historical worth of this work rests most firmly upon language. There is no longer any need to prove that Maithili can express love, folk song, narrative, theatre, or poetry. The difficult question was whether it could sustain a sequential analysis of concepts such as vyāpti, upādhi, pratiyogin, jñātatā, anvitābhidhāna, arthāpatti, anupalabdhi, extrinsic validity, counterfactual conditions, and efficient causation.

In practice, this book answers: yes.

This achievement is not simply lexical. Philosophical language is constituted through syntax. The sustained use of argumentative structures such as "if … then …," "the reply to this objection …," "but if this is accepted …," "therefore …," and "hence …" creates within this book a working grammar of Maithili intellectual prose.

10. The Bibliography and the Parallel English Section

Chapter 12: The Complete Bibliography

Chapter 12 makes this vast project accessible for research. The bibliography encompasses the foundational text and its Sanskrit editions; other writings of

Udayanācārya; primary works of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika and Navya-Nyāya; comparative sources in Mīmāṃsā, Buddhism, Sāṃkhya, Yoga, Jainism, and Vedānta; modern scholarship on Udayana; Indian poetics; Western literary theory; translation theory; and sources on Maithili language, literature, and philosophical prose. These nine categories are explicitly distinguished in the table of contents.

The bibliography's breadth accords with the interdisciplinary nature of the book. Bringing together the Nyāyasūtra, commentaries, editions of Udayana, contemporary scholarship, poetics, hermeneutics, and translation studies within one project is exceptionally useful to researchers.

The most important further improvement would be to connect every historical, linguistic, institutional, or quoted claim in the book to the relevant bibliographical entry, with a page reference or note. A bibliography at the end is not sufficient by itself; the reader needs a direct route from each assertion to its source.

The Parallel English Section

The latter portion of the book contains an extensive English rendering. It is not a short summary: it carries its own publication information and contents, research material covering Chapters 1–10, an English presentation of the complete translated text as Chapter 11, and a concluding "Complete PNS Bibliography." The English bibliography includes the primary text, Sanskrit editions, commentaries, translations, Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, rival philosophical traditions, modern studies, Indian poetics, Western criticism, and translation theory.

The cultural usefulness of the English section is evident. Philosophical knowledge produced in Maithili is no longer confined to Maithili readers: scholars across the world can gain access to its philosophical architecture and methods of translation.

There are nevertheless two problems from the standpoint of book design. First, reproducing all the material makes the book exceptionally large. Second, the absence of chapter-by-chapter and section-by-section parallel page references between the Maithili and English parts can make comparative use difficult.

A future edition would be considerably more valuable for research if the "Maithili Section" and "Parallel English Section" each began on an unambiguous divider page and a concordance were supplied matching Maithili pages and chapters with their English counterparts.

One sound principle of the English bibliography is its retention of published titles in their original foreign-language forms, preserving their identity for scholarship and library searches.

II. Repetition, Scholarly Reliability, and Editorial Refinement

The Question of Repetition Within the Book

Across Chapters 1–10, the same subjects recur repeatedly: Udayanācārya's historical position, the floral metaphor, the five clusters, śleṣa, rasa, polyphony, Nida and Venuti, the sovereignty of Maithili knowledge, parallel literature, and others.

Such repetitions could be reduced under ordinary principles of book editing. Yet the history of this volume's composition reveals two kinds of recurrence. Some instances are genuinely unnecessary; others record the progressive development of criticism—first a review based on three clusters, then a review of the later portion, and finally an examination of all five clusters.

It would therefore be inappropriate to remove every earlier review. The right course would be to place a clear statement at the beginning of each chapter, for example:

"This review was written at a specified cumulative stage of the translation";

"This chapter examines the text then available through the third cluster";

"This chapter offers a comprehensive reassessment after completion of all five clusters."

With these indications, repetition would become part of the "history of translation" rather than remain an editorial "error."

Scholarly Reliability and the Question of the Sanskrit Original

One of the book's wisest admissions is that quality in the target language and fidelity to the original are not the same thing. Even if the Maithili text is elegant, coherent, and logical, reading it alone cannot establish that the meaning of every Sanskrit expression has been preserved exactly. Determining full fidelity requires line-by-line collation with the Sanskrit original.

For that reason, an ideal future "critical research edition" would set out the original Sanskrit kārikās and prose, textual variants, and verse numbers, followed alongside by a close Maithili translation and then an explanatory Maithili rendering. The book itself recommends the Sanskrit original, Maithili text, explanation, glossary, indexes, and a digital parallel display.

Such improvements would not diminish the value of the present translation; they would safeguard its scholarly standing.

Review of Editing and Book Design

The title page, publication information, detailed contents, and chapter divisions of the present edition give it the formal character of a scholarly book. The opening pages clearly identify the original Sanskrit author, translator, editor, year of edition, and publisher.

For a bilingual research work of more than a thousand pages, however, an ordinary table of contents is inadequate. Four concluding indexes would be especially useful at this scale: philosophical terms; persons and schools; examples and illustrations; and Sanskrit kārikās. The book's own critical recommendations also call for a full subject index, a glossary of terms, an index of persons and schools, and cross-references.

A parallel Maithili–English concordance of chapters is likewise needed. Without it, an English reader searching for the equivalent English text of a particular Maithili paragraph will face difficulty.

Caution Concerning Facts and Sources

Discussions grounded in the primary philosophical text provide the book's strongest foundation. But external facts presented in Chapters 5–8—concerning language populations, modern institutions and universities, Unicode, contemporary digital language technologies, digital movements, and the institutional positions of writers—should be supported by footnotes.

Likewise, direct scholarly quotations, Vedic passages, statements from the Bhagavad Gītā and Upaniṣads, and passages attributed to the Nyāyasūtra or its commentators should identify the edition and page, kārikā, or sūtra number.

The bibliography is wide-ranging; the remaining task is to connect it with a functioning system of citations.

The Integrated Meaning of the Work's Ten Principal Intellectual Achievements

Upon reading the book as a whole, its achievements are best understood not as ten separate accomplishments but as one interconnected project. Udayanācārya's Sanskrit reasoning enters Maithili; Maithili develops a language of argument; classical terminology survives; vernacular vocabulary brings the text to life; the philosophical unity of the five clusters becomes clear; opposing positions receive a fair hearing; Indian poetics reveals the work's literary qualities; modern translation studies clarifies the translator's decisions; the research chapters identify the translation's limitations from within; and the parallel English section makes this Maithili knowledge accessible to a worldwide readership.

To call it merely "a Maithili version of Udayanācārya's book" would consequently be too narrow. It is, in reality, an effort to establish an environment for studying Nyāya philosophy in Maithili.

Further Refinements Required

On the evidence of the whole volume, the most necessary refinements operate at four levels. First, the dates and stages distinguishing the initial partial reviews from the later complete reviews should be made explicit. Second, the original text, translation, explanatory voice, and editorial commentary should be visibly distinguished. Third, parallel Sanskrit source text, kārikā numbering, textual variants, and source footnotes should be added. Fourth, Maithili–English parallel contents, a technical glossary, an index of persons, an index of illustrations, and maps of argument should be supplied.

The book already contains a remarkably clear plan pointing in this direction: original Sanskrit text with variants; readable Maithili; explanatory philosophical footnotes; a glossary, indexes, and bibliography of technical terms; and a searchable digital Sanskrit–Maithili parallel view. This is therefore not an accusation brought by an outside critic; the book itself shows the path towards its next, more mature form.

For the general reader, brief chapter-end summaries or diagrams of arguments would also be useful. Occasional Hindi-influenced forms and unnatural word order could be refined into standard Maithili. Every direct quotation should be accompanied by its stabaka, kārikā, edition, or page reference.

12. Final Comprehensive Evaluation

The greatest significance of this edition of the Nyāyakusumāñjali is that it does not merely give Maithili an opportunity to bear the weight of philosophical complexity; it demonstrates Maithili's practical ability to do so. Causality, adṛṣṭa, capacity, momentariness, validity of knowledge, the non-eternity of sound, absence, inference, comparison, verbal testimony, connected meaning, arthāpatti, non-apprehension, jñātatā, atoms, intention, injunction, and inference to God—all these diverse and subtle subjects are brought into a single tradition of prose in the mother tongue.

The translator is most successful where he neither abandons the Sanskrit term nor submits slavishly to Sanskrit sentence structure. The technical memory of the original survives while the grammar of the target language remains active. The work's authentic artistry of translation lies in that dialectical balance.

The repeated self-examination of the critical chapters is another distinctive strength. The book raises questions from within about incompleteness, editorial limitations, the absence of original Sanskrit at certain points, long sentences, and source references. A later, complete study does not render an earlier, partial study irrelevant: it transforms the earlier study into a stage in the work's history. This chronology, however, must be made explicit in the final edition.

Philosophically, the most impressive achievement is not only the eight reasons advanced in the fifth cluster but the preparation of their ground by the first four. From causality to the means of knowledge, from these to language, from language to cognition, from cognition to omniscience, and thence to inference of God: this sequence is the architecture of the Nyāyakusumāñjali. Making that architecture clear in Maithili is the translator's principal success.

Literarily, the floral metaphor binds the work from beginning to end. An argument becomes a flower; a controversy becomes a cluster; a conclusion becomes an offering in joined hands. Tranquillity, intellectual heroism, wonder, and final devotion prevent this rigorous Nyāya treatise from becoming an inert compilation of arguments.

From the perspective of translation studies, the work rejects a simple opposition between fidelity and creativity. At times the source term is retained exactly; at others, vernacular Maithili enters; elsewhere a pun unfolds into two meanings; elsewhere a sūtra becomes explanatory prose. The most fitting description is thus the one the book itself suggests: an explanatory scholarly translation.

Editorially, this massive work still holds the possibility of a more advanced "parallel critical edition." With the Sanskrit original, kārikā numbers, textual variants, a clear division between translation and explanation, source footnotes, expanded indexes, and a Maithili–English concordance, it could become not only an important translation but a standard research edition for university-level study.

The final judgement is this: the present Nyāyakusumāñjali is an exceptionally important achievement of Maithili philosophical prose. Its chief strengths lie in its complete five-cluster translation; preservation of demanding Nyāya terminology; natural Maithili sentences of argument; fair presentation of opposing positions; preservation of the meanings of puns and the floral metaphor; extensive critical self-examination; research-oriented chapters, appendices, and bibliography; and a parallel English expansion. Its principal editorial challenges are to clarify the chronology of earlier partial reviews and the present complete text; distinguish original, translation, and explanation; strengthen source documentation; and arrange the substantial recurring material in its historical sequence.

After these improvements, the work could become more than a Maithili translation of Udayanācārya's Nyāyakusumāñjali. It could serve as a lasting foundational volume for the re-establishment, in the mother tongue, of Mithila's own Nyāya tradition, the enlargement of Maithili intellectual prose, and the renewed life of classical philosophy for modern readers.

81. Tattvacintāmaṇi (Maithili Translation): A Synopsis and Critical Evaluation

Abstract

This study presents a synopsis and critical evaluation of the translated and expanded Maithili edition of the Tattvacintāmaṇi composed by Gaṅgeśopādhyāya. The work is not a novel or a poetic composition in the conventional sense, but an important classical treatise on Indian epistemology, logic, philosophy of language, and ontology.

Keywords · Translation · Tattvacintāmaṇi · Indian philosophy · Classical scholarship · Synopsis · Critical evaluation

Abstract · Synopsis

This chapter is entitled "Tattvacintāmaṇi (Maithili Translation): A Synopsis and Critical Evaluation".

A Study in the Light of Indian and Western Literary Theory

Tattvacintāmaṇi [Original Sanskrit Work: Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya · Maithili Translation: Gajendra Thakur]

This study presents a synopsis and critical assessment of the translated and expanded Maithili edition of Gaṅgeśopādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi. In the conventional sense, this is neither a novel nor a work of poetry; it is a major classical text of Indian epistemology, logic, philosophy of language, and ontology. Yet its arrangement of prima facie positions and responses (pūrvapakṣa and uttarapakṣa), the dramatic movement of its arguments, the progressive refinement of concepts, its linguistic density, and the intellectual wonder it generates make the text amenable to a range of literary-critical approaches. The study comparatively employs Indian concepts such as rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, rīti, aucitya, the powers of words, and the relationship between śāstra and kāvya, alongside Aristotelian logic, Formalism, Structuralism, hermeneutics, reader-response criticism, Deconstruction, Pragmatism, Reliabilism, and analytic philosophy. Its principal conclusion is that the literary character of the Tattvacintāmaṇi lies not in plot but in the architecture of thought, dialogic exchange, definitional discipline, and the ceaseless testing of truth. The Maithili translation re-establishes this classical inheritance within the modern intellectual world of the mother tongue and enlarges the capacities of Maithili academic prose.

Keywords: Tattvacintāmaṇi; Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya; Navya-Nyāya; Maithili translation; epistemology; Indian poetics; Western criticism; philosophy of language.

1. Introduction: Text, Tradition, Edition, and Critical Problem

Certain works in Indian intellectual history do more than expound their subject: they change the language, methods, and discipline of thinking itself. Gaṅgeśopādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi is such a work. While accepting numerous elements of the older Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika tradition, it places the investigation of the means of knowledge at the centre and develops a technical framework for analysing concepts, relations, absence, cognition, memory, error, inference, and linguistic meaning. This framework profoundly influenced almost every major subsequent school of classical Indian philosophy.

This Maithili translation of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi (translator-editor: Gajendra Thakur; Videha Publications; first edition, 2004; expanded edition, 2026; ISBN 978-93-6123-729-4) constitutes an extraordinary event in the history of Maithili prose. A work composed in fourteenth-century Mithila that transformed the direction of Indian epistemology has, seven hundred years later, returned in its entirety to the living language of its own soil for the first time. That fact itself announces the edition's cultural importance. Rendering into Maithili some of the most difficult Sanskrit scholastic prose—whose concentration of technical terminology is regarded as exceptional in the world's logical literature—was not simply an exercise in linguistic transfer. It was a severe test of Maithili's capacity to sustain scholastic discourse, and this edition demonstrates that the language can meet that test.

The architecture of the book has two levels. On the first level are six chapters, introducing, in sequence, the preliminary philosophical discussion, the section on perception, the section on inference, inference to God, the section on comparison, and the section on verbal testimony. Before readers confront the original text, these chapters furnish the necessary philosophical, historical, and terminological groundwork. At the second level, five appendices offer complete Maithili translations of the five sections: perception, inference, inference to God, comparison, and verbal testimony. A sixth appendix, in the form of a 'study companion', arranges the principal definitions, prima facie positions, established conclusions, objections, and answers in their source sequence; for teaching and revision it operates as a small book in its own right. Finally, a comprehensive verified bibliography encompasses the international scholarly tradition, from the Bibliotheca Indica and Tirupati editions to Frauwallner, Goekoop, Sibajiban Bhattacharyya, V. N. Jha, and Stephen Phillips. Thus the edition simultaneously performs four functions: translation, commentary, textbook, and research reference.

It is therefore not merely a translation but an edited intellectual enterprise that brings together access for readers, classical technical vocabulary, modern comparative perspectives, and regional intellectual history.

The critical problem posed by this study operates on two levels. First, how is the literary value of a philosophical treatise to be assessed? Second, to what

extent are the instruments of Indian and Western literary theory genuinely applicable to a classical work of logic of this kind? To answer these questions, we must understand literature not within the narrow limits of imaginative narrative or emotionally resonant verse alone, but more broadly as the ordering, in language, of human experience, knowledge, disagreement, and the making of meaning.

2. Aims, Questions, and Method of the Study

The principal aims of this study are to present a concise yet sufficiently comprehensive account of the overall conceptual structure of the Tattvacintāmaṇi; to examine the literary qualities of its scholastic prose; to determine its points of contact with Indian poetics; to reread it in the light of Western critical theories; and to evaluate the cultural and linguistic significance of its Maithili translation.

The main research questions are these: What constitutes the conceptual unity of the Tattvacintāmaṇi? How does its progression from the prima facie position to the established conclusion produce intellectual drama? How can theories such as rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, rīti, and aucitya be applied to a philosophical text? How do modern methods such as Structuralism, hermeneutics, and Deconstruction illuminate the construction of meaning in Navya-Nyāya? How does the Maithili translation preserve the density of classical scholarship while achieving intelligibility in the mother tongue?

Methodologically, the study is text-centred, comparative, interpretative, and evaluative. It examines the substance of the original arguments, their logical arrangement, examples, terminology, and linguistic style in relation to selected concepts from Indian and Western theory. Historical truth in philosophy and literary effect are considered at separate levels.

3. The Structure and Intellectual Project of the Tattvacintāmaṇi

The central inquiry of this book is how human beings acquire true knowledge, how true and false cognition can be distinguished, and which instruments of knowing qualify as pramāṇas. In place of the older Nyāya arrangement centred on sixteen categories, Gaṅgeśopādhyāya makes the examination of the means of knowledge central, offering a subtle analysis of four pramāṇas: perception, inference, comparison, and verbal testimony.

The intellectual centre of the Tattvacintāmaṇi is pramāṇa. The book's entire inquiry develops around four questions concerning these four avenues to genuine knowledge—perception, inference, comparison, and verbal testimony: how do they produce true cognition, how far does their authority extend, how do defects enter into their operations, and how is truth to be determined?

The pūrvapakṣa in the book's method of composition is no merely ceremonial opponent. The positions of Mīmāṃsakas, Buddhists, Vedāntins, grammarians, and earlier Naiyāyikas are presented in their strongest form. There follows an examination of defects such as deviation (vyabhicāra), over-extension (ativyāpti), under-extension (avyāpti), impossibility (asambhava), infinite regress (anavasthā), mutual dependence (anyonyāśraya), needless complexity (gaurava), and contradiction by stronger evidence (bādha). Definitions and established doctrines are progressively refined through this dialectical process.

The work's unity, therefore, does not consist in the mere aggregation of topics. Its unity lies in a method: no claim to knowledge is accepted until its cause, limit, object, counterexamples, and validity have been made clear. Truth here is not a conclusion fixed in advance but a process of testing.

4. Extended Synopsis of the Work

4.1 Maṅgalavāda and the Examination of Causality

The text begins with a debate about the efficacy of the auspicious invocation (maṅgalācaraṇa). The customary belief is that an invocation causes a book to be completed successfully. Gaṅgeśa tests this assertion against the criterion of positive and negative concomitance (anvaya–vyatireka). Work is sometimes completed without an invocation; conversely, even after an invocation, a book may remain unfinished because of the author's death or other circumstances. Hence the invocation is not, in itself, the direct cause of completion.

The established conclusion is that an auspicious invocation removes possible obstacles. Once obstacles are removed, ordinary causes—an author's effort, knowledge, time, and materials—bring a work to completion. The discussion thus redefines a religious practice within a logical account of causation.

Where a work is finished without an invocation, the prior absence of an obstacle is presumed. In this way, an apparently minor religious question is transformed into a serious logical inquiry into cause and effect.

4.2 Prāmāṇyavāda, Error, and the Truth of Cognition

According to the Mīmāṃsaka doctrine of intrinsic validity (svataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda), cognition discloses its own truth. For the Naiyāyika doctrine of extrinsic validity (parataḥ-prāmāṇyavāda), the truth of a cognition is not established automatically at the moment it arises; it is known through inference, successful activity, or another means of knowledge—that is, through a distinct, subsequent mental process. If every cognition were validated at the instant of its birth, doubt and error ought to be impossible. The very experience of doubt is decisive evidence against intrinsic validity.

The illusion of silver in a mother-of-pearl shell is the famous example in this dispute. In the Prābhākara view, the distinction between the shell present before the senses and the silver recalled from memory is not apprehended: illusion consists in a failure to discriminate. In the Nyāya view, silverness is positively superimposed upon the shell. Under this doctrine of anyathākhyāti, illusion is not a mere blank absence of knowledge, but a defective combination of qualificand and qualifier.

4.3 Perception, Sense–Object Contact, Absence, and Mind

Perception is regarded as immediately presentational valid cognition (sākṣātkārī pramā). Gaṅgeśa discusses the definition of perception; six kinds of ordinary sense–object contact (laukika sannikarṣa)—conjunction (saṃyoga), inherence in what is conjoined (saṃyukta-samavāya), inherence in what inheres in the conjoined (saṃyukta-samaveta-samavāya), inherence (samavāya), inherence in what inheres (samaveta-samavāya), and the relation of qualificand and qualifier (viśeṣya–viśeṣaṇa-bhāva)—and three extraordinary kinds of perception (alaukika): those mediated by universals (sāmānyalakṣaṇa), by knowledge (jñānalakṣaṇa), and by yogic capacity (yogaja). The distinction between indeterminate and determinate perception is another major concern of this section. The defence of indeterminate perception shows that, in the first experience, the object and its universal are grasped separately, not in an already synthesized form; they are received from an external reality rather than fabricated out of a conceptual void. These kinds of contact explain the perception of substances, qualities, actions, universals, sound, and absence.

Inference, comparison, and verbal testimony depend upon prior knowledge, whereas perception arises from a relation between sense faculty and object. A sense faculty is related to more than gross material substances alone.

Treating absence as a distinct reality is an important feature of Nyāya philosophy. Ground on which a pot stands and ground from which the pot is absent may be the very same visible locus, but they are different at the level of experience. Knowing that 'there is no pot on the ground' is not merely knowing the ground; it is perceiving the absence of a pot as qualifying that ground.

At this point Nyāya rejects the necessity of recognising non-apprehension (anupalabdhi) as an independent pramāṇa.

The doctrine that the mind is atomic explains the successive nature of cognitions. Were the mind all-pervading, the objects of all sense faculties would become known simultaneously. Cognition, however, arises successively. The mind is therefore held to be of atomic dimension and connected with only one sense faculty at a time. For second-order, self-referential knowledge such as 'I know that I am seeing a pot', a further mental cognition called anuvyavasāya is acknowledged.

The theory of anuvyavasāya—cognition of cognition—is among the most subtle achievements of this section: illusion is possible in external perception, but it cannot occur in the internal awareness expressed as 'The wall appears yellow to me'.

4.4 Inference, Pervasion, Parāmarśa, and Upādhi

The section on inference is the heart of Navya-Nyāya and the logical climax of the work. It analyses inferential cognition (anumiti), invariable concomitance or pervasion (vyāpti), the status of the subject (pakṣatā), the synthesizing consideration called parāmarśa, limiting conditions (upādhi), hypothetical reasoning (tarka), exclusively affirmative and exclusively negative inferences (kevalānvayī and kevalavyatirekī), and fallacious reasons (hetvābhāsa). The search for a flawless definition of vyāpti—the inseparable relation between probandum (sādhya) and reason (hetu)—begins with the celebrated Vyāptipañcaka and advances towards the formulation known as the Siṃha-vyāghrī definition. The means of apprehending pervasion, the role of tarka, the necessity of contact mediated by a universal (sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyāsatti), and the doctrine of upādhi together construct a comprehensive philosophy of inductive knowledge. Pakṣatā is defined as 'siṣādhayiṣā-viraha-viśiṣṭa-siddhyabhāva', thus binding a psychological precondition of inference to logical exactitude.

Inference produces knowledge of a probandum not previously known. Seeing smoke on a mountain permits the inference of fire when the invariable concomitance of smoke and fire is remembered and the presence, in this particular mountain, of smoke qualified by that concomitance is apprehended as a property of the subject. This combined cognition is called parāmarśa.

When defining vyāpti, Gaṅgeśa successively removes possible defects of over-extension, under-extension, impossibility, and contamination by limiting conditions (upādhi). Under this method a definition is not a fixed sentence, but a concept purified in the fire of objections from opposing positions.

It is not enough merely to say, 'Wherever the reason is present, the probandum is present', because concomitance subject to a limiting condition can be irregular.

An upādhi is a concealed condition that accompanies the probandum but not invariably the proposed reason. The inference 'There is fire; therefore there is smoke' is vitiated by the limiting condition of damp fuel, since every fire does not generate smoke. The upādhi thus exposes the difference between observable correlation and genuine invariable concomitance.

The three forms of inference—kevalānvayī, anvayavyatirekī, and kevalavyatirekī—clarify differing circumstances of positive and negative concomitance. Nyāya incorporates the Mīmāṃsaka's supposedly independent

pramāṇa of postulation (arthāpatti) within exclusively negative inference, thereby adopting the principle of explanatory economy (lāghava).

4.5 The Five Members of Inference, Debate, and Fallacious Reasons

The five members of a Nyāya argument—proposition (pratijñā), reason (hetu), example (udāharaṇa), application (upanaya), and conclusion (nigamana)—make reasoning public, sequential, and open to examination. The example displays the general rule of pervasion; application brings that rule to bear on the present subject; the conclusion establishes the result.

Hetvābhāsas constitute a systematic classification of internal defects in reasoning. Savyabhicāra denotes an irregular or inconclusive reason; viruddha, a reason establishing the opposite conclusion; satpratipakṣa, an equally powerful counter-reason; asiddha, an unestablished reason; and bādhita, a probandum already defeated by a stronger means of knowledge. This classification is not merely an instrument of scholastic disputation. It retains its usefulness in modern intellectual controversy, judicial reasoning, scientific demonstration, and public dialogue.

4.6 Inference to God, Causal Powers, and Human Ends

Inference to God is founded not on an emotional impulse of faith but on cause-and-effect relations. The earth and other entities are effects; effects require an intelligent maker; accordingly, God is posited as the efficient cause of the universe. Atoms are the material causes, while God is the coordinating efficient cause.

The section on inference to God defends the five-membered inference expressed as 'kṣityaṅkurādikaṃ sakartṛkaṃ kāryatvāt ghaṭavat' ('Earth, sprouts, and the like have a maker, because they are products, like a pot') against a succession of attacks by opponents. Its orderly answers to objections concerning the absence of a common form encompassing the subject, mutual dependence, dubious inconclusiveness, the proof of what is already established, and diversion to a different issue make the section one of the most rigorous logical documents in the Indian philosophical debate over theism.

Objections to the argument include the possibility of a bodiless agent, a plurality of agents, the independent operation of unseen potency (adṛṣṭa), and the natural formation of the world. The Nyāya tradition responds by appealing to will, cognition, effort, power, and the distribution of the fruits of action.

The discussion also examines the theory of the power to burn, the absence of obstructing conditions, causal relations, the doctrine of human ends, the fruits of karma, and liberation. Here God is not simply an object of faith but the object of inference: a conclusion tested by the criteria of subject, probandum, reason, pervasion, and limiting condition.

The work makes the question of God's existence a subject of public reasoning rather than of emotional intensity or religious command.

4.7 Comparison: Knowledge of a Name through Resemblance

Upamāna is knowledge of the relation between a name and its bearer acquired through resemblance. A person who has been told that 'the gavaya is a wild animal resembling a cow' sees a cow-like creature in a forest and understands, 'This creature is called a gavaya'. What arises here is not simply an awareness of resemblance, but a new understanding of the relation between a previously heard word and a presently encountered object.

Gaṅgeśa does not wholly reduce comparison to perception, inference, or verbal testimony. Its independence lies in its distinctive outcome: through a known resemblance, the referent of a word is identified. The inquiry raises subtle questions about the reality of resemblance, unity, plurality, similarity of properties, and the signifying power of words.

4.8 Verbal Testimony, Sentence Meaning, and Intention

The section on verbal testimony is exceptionally rich from the standpoint of the philosophy of language. Words become a pramāṇa when a meaningful utterance by a trustworthy speaker produces true cognition in a listener. Understanding a sentence is held to require expectancy (ākāṅkṣā), semantic compatibility (yogyatā), proximity (āsatti), and intention (tātparya).

Ākāṅkṣā is the mutual expectancy among words; yogyatā is the possible compatibility of their meanings; āsatti is their appropriate closeness; and tātparya is the meaning intended by the speaker. In the instruction 'Sprinkle with fire', grammatical expectancy may be present, but semantic compatibility is absent. In irony, ambiguity, secondary signification, and contextual meaning, the speaker's intention becomes decisive.

The section on words discusses universals and particulars, primary and secondary signification (abhidhā and lakṣaṇā), derivation and established usage (yoga and rūḍhi), compounds, verbal roots, finite verbal forms, prefixes, and the meaning of injunctions. It is consequently not merely a study of the means of knowledge, but also a developed theory of semantics and sentences.

The refutation of Buddhist and Vaiśeṣika objections, the establishment of the non-eternity of words, and the debate over the human authorship of the Vedas are among its other major subjects. In this way, the book builds a complete and internally consistent epistemological architecture out of the four sources of knowledge: perception, inference, comparison, and verbal testimony.

5. Intellectual Drama and Scholastic Prose in the Work

Although it is not a novel, the work possesses a distinctive dramatic movement within its internal structure. Five stages are generally discernible in each discussion:

The pūrvapakṣa presents its position;

The advocate of the established position identifies defects in it;

The pūrvapakṣa responds to those criticisms;

The defender of the established position refines the definition;

Finally, a conclusion is established that is either free from defects or comparatively more defensible.

This structure is the intellectual theatre of classical debate. Philosophical positions take the place of characters; conceptual opposition takes the place of conflict; the most subtle objection assumes the role of climax; and the definition of an established doctrine supplies the resolution. The reader is no passive listener but becomes a fellow thinker who searches each argument for its potential defects.

The dramatic tension arises from the question of whether a proposed definition can withstand the next objection.

The beauty of scholastic prose resides chiefly in terminological discipline, sequential reasoning, and conceptual density. The sentence is intended not to decorate, but to delimit meaning.

6. A Critical Reading in the Light of Indian Literary Theory

6.1 Rasa: Intellectual Wonder and Tranquillity

From the standpoint of traditional rasa theory, a philosophical treatise does not directly organize the emotions of erotic love (śṛṅgāra), compassion (karuṇa), or heroism (vīra). Yet, at the level of the experience of knowing, the dominant sentiment of this work is 'intellectual wonder'. The subtle resolution of complex problems, the disclosure of logical structures concealed within everyday experience, and the gradual refinement of definitions all produce astonishment.

Rasa theory is principally concerned with the emotional experience of drama and poetry. The Tattvacintāmaṇi offers no such conventional artistic design, yet the experience of knowing creates the possibility of an effect comparable to rasa.

The possibility of śānta rasa also lies within the work's ultimate human purpose. The supreme aim of Nyāya philosophy is to obtain liberation (apavarga) through true knowledge, breaking the chain of false knowledge, defects, activity, birth, and suffering. Thus the intellectual journey of this treatise is ultimately linked to the spiritual goal of peace.

6.2 Dhvani: Testing Truth, Intellectual Ethics, and Cultural Suggestion of an Idea

Ānandavardhana's theory of dhvani concentrates primarily on the suggestive meaning of poetry. The Tattvacintāmaṇi, by contrast, is overtly a text of direct signification and definition. Nevertheless, its wider cultural suggestion is unmistakable: truth is not received solely from tradition; it must undergo the tests of reasoning, opposition, exception, and experience.

Every section of the treatise implicitly suggests intellectual independence. Even the doctrine of one's own school is not exempt from criticism. In this sense the work's deepest dhvani is the 'responsibility of thought'.

It is not proper to defeat an adversary by weakening their position; one should present its strongest form and then answer it.

Ānandavardhana's theory of suggestion cannot be applied directly to scholastic prose: the purpose of śāstra is what is explicitly stated, not what is suggested. Nevertheless, a suggestion of an idea (vastu-dhvani) certainly emerges from the overall arrangement of this edition: a work composed on Mithila's soil returns in Mithila's language. This fact is not expressly proclaimed, yet every page implies that Maithili is not merely a language of songs and stories; it is a language capable of the theory of the means of knowledge. This may be regarded as the edition's most profound suggested meaning (vyaṅgyārtha).

6.3 Vakrokti: Conceptual Deflection in the Act of Seeing

Kuntaka's vakrokti is a theory of the distinctive obliqueness of expression and aesthetic beauty in poetry. Instead of ornamental obliqueness, Navya-Nyāya prose produces conceptual obliqueness. Ordinary language treats 'absence', 'relation', 'knowledge', or 'similarity' as straightforward; Gaṅgeśa reverses their apparent simplicity and discloses the complexity within them.

The obliqueness, then, lies not in figures of speech but in the standpoint adopted. 'Not being seen' is not the same as 'the perception of absence'; 'two objects are alike' is not the same as asking 'by which property is their similarity delimited?' The distinctive beauty of the work lies in this analytical displacement.

6.4 Rīti, Guṇa, and the Tradition of Scholastic Prose

Indian literary theory recognises a distinction between poetry and śāstra, but scholastic prose also possesses an aesthetics of its own. From Vātsyāyana's commentary to Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali, classical philosophical prose has touched poetic excellence through maturity, weight of meaning, and skill in sentence construction. The original prose of Navya-Nyāya represents an extreme of the densely compounded Gauḍī style; the prose of the present translation comes closer to the Vaidarbhī style, with fewer compounds, a

predominance of clarity (prasāda-guṇa), and force (ojas) wherever the sharpness of reasoning demands it.

Nevertheless, the subtlety of the subject means that clarity is not uniformly achieved everywhere. Force is especially evident in refutation, the exposure of defects, and the establishment of doctrines; intellectual firmness and definitional rigour take precedence over sweetness (mādhurya). The translator protects without alteration such technical terms as avacchedaka, pratiyogitā, anuyogitā, and siṣādhayiṣā, while the introductory chapters, examples, and accessible exposition make it easier for readers to enter the text.

This balance meets the requirements of Kṣemendra's theory of propriety (aucitya) particularly well. In a translation of śāstra, propriety demands that simplification should not come at the cost of meaning, and that technicality should not become an excuse for obscurity. In a construction such as 'If the Mīmāṃsaka position is accepted … doubt in a state of non-practice would become entirely impossible', both the sharp edge of the original argument and the natural syntactic order of Maithili are preserved.

6.5 Aucitya: Difficulty, Extent, and Purpose

From Kṣemendra's perspective of aucitya, there is a profound congruity among the language, subject matter, and purpose of the work. Subtle entities require subtle technical terminology for their examination. If the concepts of Navya-Nyāya are simplified excessively, their logical boundaries disappear. Difficulty, therefore, is not invariably a defect; some difficulty is a consequence of what is appropriate to the subject.

It is difficult to express subtle relations without such terms as avacchedaka, pratiyogitā, nirūpakatā, and samānādhikaraṇya.

Nevertheless, when the same conclusion is repeated many times as a question-and-answer exchange, synopsis, and restatement, propriety becomes less secure. Repetition intended to assist teaching may be useful to beginners, but for expert readers such length can become burdensome.

An ideal edition should arrange the original translation, accessible explanation, research notes, and practice materials on distinct levels.

6.6 The Powers of Words, the Function of Intention, and Self-Reflective Translation

The section on words supplies, from within Indian semantics itself, the critical instruments for examining the work. Questions of primary signification (abhidhā), secondary signification (lakṣaṇā), derivation (yoga), convention (rūḍhi), universals (jāti), particulars (vyakti), intention (tātparya), and sentence meaning (vākyārtha) are not simply an external study of language: the book also tests the conditions of its own expression.

This self-reflective character makes the Tattvacintāmaṇi a work that philosophises by means of language while simultaneously investigating the nature of language in a philosophical manner.

The book performs philosophy through language and, through philosophy, determines language's limits, capacities, and ability to function as a means of knowledge.

The most intriguing literary-theoretical dimension of this book is that it carries within itself the principles governing its own translation. The four factors of verbal understanding established in its section on words—expectancy (ākāṅkṣā), semantic compatibility (yogyatā), proximity (āsatti), and intention (tātparya)—also constitute four tests of the act of translation. The translator must grasp the mutual expectancy of the words in the original sentence; ensure their semantic compatibility in the target language; preserve the appropriate closeness and order of the words in the sentence; and, above all, determine the author's intended meaning. The Naiyāyika doctrine of tātparya, which treats the speaker's intention as decisive in determining meaning, provides the classical foundation for the translator's own work. In this sense, the translation is a self-reflective (self-aware) text: it is translated according to the very principles it translates. Within the historical conflict between Bhartṛhari's theory of sphoṭa and the Naiyāyika account of verbal understanding arising from the successive connection of words, this translation supplies a practical instance of the Nyāya position: sentence meaning is constructed through the relation between words and their referents and is, therefore, translatable.

7. A Rereading in the Light of Western Critical Theory

7.1 Aristotelian Logic and Rhetoric

Aristotle's rhetoric identifies three principal elements: the credibility of the speaker, the emotions of the audience, and the proof supplied by argument. In the Tattvacintāmaṇi, emotional persuasion occupies relatively little space, and rational demonstration is supreme. Nevertheless, the doctrine of reliable testimony (āptavākya), by raising questions of the speaker's credibility, knowledge, and freedom from defective intentions, enters into dialogue with the Aristotelian notion of the trustworthy speaker.

Nyāya's five-membered inference is more dialogic than the Aristotelian three-part syllogism. Through the example, application, and conclusion, it does not simply announce a result; it leads the listener step by step from the general rule to the subject under consideration.

7.2 Formalism and Defamiliarisation

Russian Formalism emphasises the devices and methods by which a literary work is constructed. From this standpoint, the manner of presentation in the Tattvacintāmaṇi is as important as its actual 'subject matter'. The recurring

pattern of prima facie position, response, defect, solution, delimitor, and final definition constitutes the work's primary compositional device.

These devices make ordinary ideas unfamiliar. Acts such as 'seeing', 'not existing', 'being similar', and 'knowing', which seem self-evident in daily life, become complex philosophical events in the treatise. Such defamiliarisation is a principal source of its intellectual force.

7.3 Structuralism: A Network of Relations That Produces Meaning

Structuralist analysis sees meaning not in isolated objects but in networks of relations. Navya-Nyāya similarly depends on relational structures: qualificand and qualifier, locus and dependent, property and property-bearer, counterpositive and absence, probandum and reason, word and meaning, and knower and known.

No element, therefore, is fully defined in isolation: its boundaries are established by relations and differences with other elements. In this respect, the Navya-Nyāya concept of the delimitor (avacchedaka) comes remarkably close to modern structural thinking. The difference, however, is that Structuralism commonly gives priority to linguistic structures, whereas Nyāya accepts the real existence of a world beyond language.

7.4 Hermeneutics and Analytic Philosophy

Hermeneutics in the tradition of Gadamer holds that readers approach a text with their own historical horizons. In this Maithili translation, the horizon of classical Sanskrit scholarship meets that of modern Maithili readers. Translation is not merely a substitution of words; it is a dialogue between tradition and the present.

The introductory chapters, examples, explanations of technical vocabulary, and study companion prepare the reader's prior understanding. Translation consequently becomes not simply a repetition of the original, but an interpretative bridge.

From a hermeneutic standpoint, however, every act of simplification by the translator is also an act of selection. Where the original's multiplicity of meanings or disputed character is reduced to one determinate interpretation, readers may lose access to other possible meanings. A three-tier arrangement of original Sanskrit terminology, Maithili translation, and necessary textual notes would therefore be particularly useful for a work of this kind.

Gadamer's concept of the fusion of horizons (Horizontverschmelzung) offers a precise explanation of this edition's two-level architecture: the horizon of the fourteenth-century scholastic assembly and that of the twenty-first-century Maithili reader come together in the introductory chapters. This is where Gaṅgeśa enters into dialogue with contemporary concepts of analytic epistemology, such as 'reliabilism', 'externalism', and 'fallibilism'. The dialogue is, in the study's account, earned rather than imposed: the scholarly

tradition represented by Ingalls, Matilal, Sibajiban Bhattacharyya, and Stephen Phillips has already demonstrated the comparability of Gaṅgeśa's analysis of qualificands and qualifiers with the logical analyses of Frege and Russell, and the anticipations of contemporary reliabilist epistemology in his doctrine of extrinsic validity. The introductory chapters of this edition make that comparative discussion systematically available in Maithili for the first time.

7.5 Reader Response: Two Levels of Readership

The work constructs two kinds of readers. The first is the beginner, who needs questions and answers, examples, accessible explanations, and chapter introductions. The second is the specialist, who seeks the original reasoning, variant readings, the sources and traditions underlying the prima facie positions, distinctions among technical terms, and finer conceptual subtleties.

This edition attempts to address both groups. As a consequence, the explanatory material is at times very simple, while the original text in translation is at times extremely dense. This two-level character increases the work's usefulness but occasionally disrupts stylistic consistency.

An attempt to fulfil both expectations through a single continuous style sometimes produces unevenness; a layered arrangement would be more appropriate.

7.6 Deconstruction: The Persistent Instability of Definitions

Deconstructive criticism uncovers tensions and unstable boundaries within a text. The Tattvacintāmaṇi attempts to establish clear distinctions between truth and falsity, valid and invalid cognition, presence and absence, perception and memory, and word and meaning. Yet the treatise's own discussions show that establishing these boundaries demands a continual addition of qualifications, delimitors, and exceptions.

This does not demonstrate the failure of the work; on the contrary, it testifies to its philosophical honesty. Every definition invites its possible undoing and is then reconstructed in a more subtle form. In this sense, the Tattvacintāmaṇi is not a book of permanently fixed meaning, but of continual discipline and revision in the construction of meaning.

7.7 Pragmatism, Reliabilism, and Externalism

The Nyāya view that the truth of cognition can be determined by successful activity comes close to modern Pragmatism. If action prompted by knowledge of water succeeds in quenching thirst, that cognition has proved successful and valid. At the same time, the truth of cognition is related to an appropriate causal sequence, a position resembling modern reliabilist epistemology. The present work also relates Gaṅgeśa's philosophy to objective causal processes and external realism. For these reasons, Nyāya appears close to contemporary Reliabilism and Externalism as well.

Nevertheless, Nyāya does not reduce truth to utility alone.

7.8 Translation Theory: Schleiermacher, Benjamin, and Venuti

Friedrich Schleiermacher's celebrated division—whether the translator should take readers towards the author or bring the author towards readers—finds a third path in this translation. The introductory chapters lead the reader towards Gaṅgeśa; the complete translations in the appendices bring Gaṅgeśa into the courtyard of the Maithili reader. In Lawrence Venuti's terms, the translation favours 'foreignisation': technical expressions such as avacchedakatva, pratiyogitā, and sandigdhānaikāntikatā are left untranslated because their terminological precision is the lifeblood of Navya-Nyāya. 'Domestication' takes place only at the level of syntax and the arrangement of words. Viewed through Walter Benjamin's 'The Task of the Translator', the translation is an 'afterlife' (Fortleben) of the original: the Tattvacintāmaṇi has not merely been preserved but revived, while Maithili has discovered, through this process, the possibilities of its own 'pure language'—its capacity to bear scholastic discourse.

7.9 Paratext, Reception, and the Recovery of Subjugated Knowledge

In the light of Gérard Genette's theory of paratext, the introductory chapters, study companion, and verified bibliography are not merely supplementary material; they are active instruments in the production of meaning. These paratexts make the work usable in research and shape the reader's horizon of expectations (Jauss's Erwartungshorizont). The most affecting Western parallel, however, is found in Foucault's notion of 'subjugated knowledges' and the approach of Subaltern history. The parallel, Pañjī-based account of Gaṅgeśa's biography—its allegations regarding an inter-caste marriage, connections to a leatherworkers' settlement, and the silence of mainstream biography about these matters—raises questions about the relationship between knowledge, caste, and prestige in medieval Mithila. The study describes this as an example of the genealogical method of historiography. In the author's argument, the very life of one of India's greatest logicians was a battleground between reasoning and social structure, a conflict that remains unresolved in the writing of history today.

8. The Maithili Translation: Craft, Language, Tradition, and the Democratisation of Knowledge

The translator's language policy rests on three pillars. First is terminological integrity: the technical vocabulary of Navya-Nyāya is kept intact, with English equivalents, such as 'Invariable Concomitance', 'Apperception', and 'Qualificandum', supplied in parentheses at first use, thereby connecting the work with international scholarship. Second is the Maithilisation of sentence structure: long Sanskrit strings of compounds are divided into the natural syntactic order of Maithili. Formulae of negation such as 'Nor should it be said that …' and 'Nor can even this be said …' keep the

movement of scholastic debate alive in Maithili prose. Third is the dramatic clarity of the sequence from pūrvapakṣa to siddhānta: objections, refutations, restatements, and conclusions are marked with subheadings so that the complete dramatic structure of debate—what Western scholars have called 'dialectical theatre'—is enacted before the reader. The grammatical resources of Maithili, including honorific verb forms, the distinction between 'chathi' and 'achi', and the logical connective force of 'seho', 'ta', and 'mudā', prove fully capable of bearing the subtle differences of scholastic discussion. This itself constitutes the enduring linguistic evidential value of the translation.

Mithila was the birthplace of Navya-Nyāya, yet much of its primary material remained restricted to Sanskrit or foreign languages for modern Maithili readers. The translation lessens this historical irony: it is an act of cultural reclamation and the linguistic democratisation of knowledge.

The exposition of such subjects as prāmāṇya, vyāpti, avacchedaka, pratiyogitā, upādhi, anuvyavasāya, and tātparya demonstrates the capacities of Maithili academic prose.

It establishes that Maithili is not merely a language of feeling, folk poetry, domestic life, popular culture, songs and stories, or emotional expression, but an effective vehicle for subtle logic, epistemology, the philosophy of language, and ontology. It reconnects Mithila's philosophical inheritance with the present linguistic community and expands the possibilities of Maithili academic prose through the creation of technical vocabulary and the ordering of scholarly sentences.

The historical importance of the translation also lies in restoring Mithila's classical rationalism to the linguistic rights of the modern Maithili-speaking public.

The principal challenge is terminological consistency. Different Maithili renderings of the same Sanskrit term, unnecessary foreign-language glosses in parentheses, excessive literalness, or excessive simplification can all alter the boundaries of meaning.

9. Principal Artistic, Intellectual, and Cultural Achievements

The work's greatest achievement is logical subtlety. Before any definition is accepted, every possible exception to it is sought. Such intellectual discipline transforms the reader's very way of thinking.

Its second achievement is dialogic openness. Opposing positions are not presented in their weakest form; instead, their most powerful arguments are stated and answered. The treatise thus offers a genuine ideal of classical debate.

The third achievement is its demonstration of the inseparable connection between knowledge and language. Truth is not derived only from objects; understanding it depends on words, relations, memory, intention, sense–object contact, and mental processes.

The interconnections among epistemology, ontology, philosophy of language, and psychology constitute another major achievement of the work.

A fourth achievement is intellectual ethics. The treatise teaches its readers that one must examine reasons before falling in love with conclusions; respect for tradition must not become a reason to prevent its critical examination.

Making a vast treasury of classical knowledge available in Maithili is the distinctive cultural accomplishment of this edition.

10. Conclusion

The Tattvacintāmaṇi is not merely a historical inheritance of Indian philosophy; it is a method of thought. It is a great monument of Indian rationalism. Its fundamental power lies not simply in establishing any one doctrine, but in constructing a disciplined method of thinking. The text teaches that a claim to knowledge is acceptable only when its cause is clear, its range is secure, objections and counterexamples have been answered, and its language is free from confusion.

It may finally be said that the true protagonist of the Tattvacintāmaṇi is not any individual but 'true knowledge'. Its conflict is with ignorance, illusion, obscurity, and definitions that fail to cover their intended cases. Its narrative is the story of the progressive refinement of thought; and its ultimate achievement lies in making human intelligence more subtle, responsible, and directed towards truth.

Every claim must face questioning, every definition an exception, every conclusion evidence, and every use of language responsibility for meaning.

Taken as a whole, this edition is historically significant on three levels. At the epistemological level, it makes Gaṅgeśa's complete fourfold system of the means of knowledge available as a whole in Maithili for the first time. At the linguistic level, it provides decisive evidence of Maithili's capacity to sustain scholastic discourse: the language that can sing Vidyāpati's lyric compositions can also convey the subtleties of the Siṃha-vyāghrī definition. At the cultural level, it is the repayment of a historical debt: the work Mithila gave to the world has travelled around that world—through Calcutta, Tirupati, Vienna, and Harvard—and returned to the language of its birthplace. Whether judged by the Indian poetics of propriety and intention or by Western theories of translation and hermeneutics, the work emerges as a mature, self-aware, and enduringly important translation of śāstra, opening a new chapter of classical scholarly prose in the history of Maithili writing.

11. Comparative Table

Critical perspective	Relevant element in the Tattvacintāmaṇi	Principal conclusion
Rasa theory	Wonder generated by reasoning; the goal of overcoming suffering	Intellectual wonder culminating in tranquillity

Critical perspective	Relevant element in the Tattvacintāmaṇi	Principal conclusion
Dhvani	Continuous testing of claims received from tradition	Intellectual ethics and orientation towards truth
Vakrokti	Conceptual reconstruction of ordinary experience	An oblique perspective as the work's aesthetic force
Aucitya	Technical difficulty appropriate to a subtle subject	Necessary difficulty is justified; repetition should be limited
Formalism	Structure of pūrvapakṣa, defect, and established doctrine	The mode of presentation is as influential as the subject matter
Structuralism	Qualificand–qualifier, reason–probandum, counterpositive–absence	Meaning constructed through a network of relations
Hermeneutics	Dialogue between the Sanskrit original and modern Maithili readers	Translation as a fusion of horizons
Deconstruction	Unceasing revision of definitions	Disciplined refinement rather than fixed meaning
Reliabilism	True cognition arising from appropriate causal conditions	The truth of knowledge is procedural and objective

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Miscellaneous Criticism

82. Sīt–Basant: A Folktale Based on Fieldwork

Abstract

Gajendra Thakur (village Menhath, via Jhanjharpur, Madhubani district). Special assistance: Shri Keshav Mahato (Bahadurganj, Kishanganj district, Bihar). Shri Keshav Mahato, an informant in this fieldwork, is a co-author of this essay because of his exceptional contribution to the field study of Sīt–Basant. Several different versions of the story of Sīt–Basant were recorded; the particulars of these versions are given at the appropriate places.

Keywords: fieldwork · folktale · Sīt · Basant · literary criticism · Maithili

Gajendra Thakur (village Menhath, via Jhanjharpur, Madhubani district).

Special assistance: Shri Keshav Mahato (Bahadurganj, Kishanganj district, Bihar).

Shri Keshav Mahato, an informant for this fieldwork, is a co-author of this essay on account of his special assistance with the field study of Sīt–Basant. Several different versions of the story of Sīt–Basant were found, and their details are recorded in the places where they arise. Folktales are exceedingly important for understanding society and culture; yet a folktale written without fieldwork cannot fulfil its purpose. I am also grateful to Shri Subhash Chandra Yadav, whose paper on this subject—fieldwork and folktales—I heard at a seminar and which inspired me to pursue this work with greater dedication.

Modern techniques of fieldwork were used for this study. The folktale was constructed on the basis of participation, observation, interviews, questionnaires and related methods. Altering the form of a folktale or folk poem in any way is unscientific, and care has been taken to avoid doing so here.

Maheshwar Singh was the king of the city of Manipur.

He was a mighty king, and he governed his kingdom very well.

After some time, two sons were born to the king.

His queen, too, was a woman of good conduct and self-respect.

This is something that happened once.

The queen lived in her palace, and for a long time two paurkī birds—doves—had made a nest there. One day the female laid two eggs in the nest, and two chicks hatched from them. Then, unexpectedly, the mother of those chicks died. The little birds began to suffer greatly. After some days their father brought back another female paurkī from the forest as his new mate. Two or four days passed somehow. Then one day, as the new mate fed the two chicks, she put thorns into their mouths. Both chicks died at once. After they had died, she pushed them out of the nest with her beak so that they fell to the ground. The queen was in the palace at the time and saw her throw the chicks

down. From that day a fear arose in the queen's mind, and anxiety beset her continually.

The queen said to the king: "O King, look! Two paurkī birds used to live in our palace. They had two chicks. The chicks' mother died, and afterwards the father brought home a second wife. Within a few days she killed both chicks. So, O King, if I, too, should die and you marry again, might not the same thing happen to our two children?"

The king replied, "My queen, you are still alive. Why are you worrying about such a thing now?"

The queen said, "No, O King. If I die, surely you will not marry again?"

The king answered, "No. I shall not marry a second time."

Saying this, the king went back to the entrance of his residence.

From that day the queen grew sorrowful, and one day she died unexpectedly.

The king was greatly troubled by what had happened. His two sons, Sīt and Basant, were also plunged into difficulty.

The king's female attendant, ministers, clerks and many others began to advise him.

They said, "Your Majesty, if you do not marry again, what will become of these two children? There will be no proper arrangement for either their food or their education. That is why you should marry."

Persuaded in this way, the king said, "Very well. Since that is the opinion of all of you, go and find a girl from a poor family, and I shall marry her."

Once they had understood and considered the king's words, his clerks and ministers began looking for a girl. They found one in the king's own city. She was the daughter of a very poor family. At an auspicious time fixed for the marriage, the king married her and brought her home. For a while she lived peacefully in the household. After some days her affection for the two brothers began to lessen. The boys used to return from school and play with a ball outside their door. One day, quite by accident, the ball fell into the courtyard.

Their stepmother was in the courtyard at that moment. As soon as the ball fell, she picked it up and kept it in her lap. Searching for it, the two brothers came into the courtyard and said, "Mother, please give us our ball. The two of us were playing with it." Their mother replied, "I have no ball. Go away." But the two brothers could see the ball in her lap. They asked again: "Mother, please give us the ball. We want to play." They went on asking until they took the ball out of her lap. When the ball was taken away, great anger rose in the queen's heart. Filled with rage, she lay down on a couch and gave up eating and drinking. Her attendants exhausted themselves trying to persuade her: "Come, Your Majesty, let us have something to eat." But the queen gave no answer. She said, "Now I shall die." Hearing this, an attendant went to the king and said, "The queen is desperately unhappy. She may not survive. Please

go and see her." At these words the king went to the palace and questioned the queen: "How have you come to such a state? Tell me at once."

The queen said, "If you are asking me, first swear an oath to me, and then I will tell you. Otherwise I shall die." Without thinking, the king made the promise. After he had sworn, the queen said, "Your two sons have brought me to this condition. There is only one cure for my sickness; otherwise I cannot live. You must kill both of them, take out their hearts and bring the hearts to me. Only then can I recover." Hearing this, the king became terribly angry. He summoned both his sons, beat them severely and sent them off to be killed by executioners. The executioners dragged the brothers, beating them, into the forest. The brothers were weeping bitterly. When the executioners were about to kill them, they pleaded: "Do not kill us. If you let us go, we will never return to the city. Kill an animal instead and take its heart back with you." Saying this, the two brothers also handed over all the money they had. One executioner said, "Kill them." Another said, "No, do not kill them. Even if they return, we can say, 'What could we do? We brought back their hearts. They must have come back to life after they died.'"

The executioners did just that and set both brothers free.

Story version 1: The executioners did just that and set both brothers free.

The brothers began wandering through the forest. At night they lay down to sleep beneath a tree. After a while they woke and saw a snake climbing it. Two young swans lived in that tree; their parents had gone out to forage. On seeing the snake, the young swans began to cry out.

The brothers thought, "Look, this snake will eat the young birds." So they struck it with a sword, killed it and knocked it to the ground. The chicks stopped crying. When morning came, the male and female swans returned from feeding and brought food for their young. But when the mother tried to feed them, the chicks refused and said, "Mother, tell us this: are we the first young you have raised in this tree, or have you had chicks here before?" Their mother replied, "I have had chicks here before, but you two are the only ones whose faces I have ever lived to see."

Story version 2, more popular and widespread in the area: The executioners did just that and set both brothers free.

The two brothers wandered about the forest for a long time. At night they slept beneath a tree. In the morning they set out from the forest towards another country. Overcome by hunger and thirst, they sat beneath a tree to rest, wondering what they could do. In that tree were two young mynah birds. One said, "Whoever eats my flesh raw will very soon obtain a kingdom." The other said, "Whoever roasts and eats me will become a king after some days." The brothers heard this. Taking a stick, they struck down and killed both young birds, picked them up and went on. A little farther ahead they saw herdsmen tending cows and buffaloes and burning a tangle of thorny ber bushes. The brothers thought, "Let us roast these birds in that fire and eat

them." They roasted the two young mynahs in the fire and ate them. Because they cooked them among thorns, thorns entered their destiny as well.

The brothers moved on from there. After walking a little farther, they came upon a mango grove.

Basant had grown exhausted from walking and could go no farther.

Sīt said, "Brother, sit here. I shall go to that village and beg for something to eat. Then we can eat and continue on our way." Sīt went into the village to beg. In the village he entered—called Hastinapur in some tellings of story version 3—the king had arranged a svayaṃvara, in which his daughter would choose a husband. A great crowd had gathered. Sīt stopped to see what was happening. He became absorbed in the spectacle and forgot his brother. At the svayaṃvara the princess walked around the assembly carrying the wedding garland and placed it around Sīt's neck. Sīt was married to the girl then and there.

(Version 4.) Before the marriage, the people present began to say, "Though she is a king's daughter, she has put the garland around a beggar's neck! The girl must have lost her senses. Take the garland off his neck and put it around someone else's, or we shall not allow the marriage." Hearing them, the girl said, "If it is this very beggar who is written into my fate, where would I find a king instead? I shall marry him." All the assembled kings departed for their homes, saying, "Drive this girl out of the village and send her elsewhere." The king did so: he sent the couple out of his village. They began to live nearby, in the same town. After some time, people again urged the king to separate his daughter from the young man and marry her to someone else.

At everyone's insistence, the king sent a scheming old woman, carrying poison, to the place where Sīt and the princess were living. The old woman began staying with them. Several days passed and neither of the couple suspected anything. One day Sīt suddenly became extremely thirsty and said to his wife, "Please give me some water to drink." The old woman sprang up at once, dissolved poison in a glass of water and handed it to Sīt. As he was desperately thirsty, he took the water and drank it immediately. After a short time, the poison began to affect him strongly; its effects gradually increased and he became drowsy. The old woman said, "Nothing is wrong. Do not worry. Everything will be all right." A little while later Sīt died. His wife wept inconsolably. There was no village near the place. They carried Sīt to the riverbank and buried him there. The old woman said, "Look, do not be anxious now. Let us bathe." When they went to bathe, a boat was moored at the bank. The old woman said, "Come, we can sit on that boat and bathe." The two sat on the boat and began bathing. Slowly the boat began to move away. When it reached midstream—version 5 also calls the princess Phulvantī—the princess realised the boat was already in the middle of the current. She understood that the old woman was deceiving and carrying her away. Grieving for her dead husband, she thought, "When my husband has died, what use is there in my remaining alive?" With that thought she leapt from the boat into the river. She was carried a long way downstream before the current washed her ashore.

Now, the story of Basant:

Basant remained in the mango grove, waiting for his brother. Day turned to evening. Some potters were gathering dry leaves in the grove. Weeping, Basant went up to one of them. The potter asked, "Why are you crying?" Basant told him everything. The potter said, "Do not worry. Come to my house. You may stay there." Basant went with the potter and began living in his home. While he was staying there, a travelling merchant set out on a trading journey in his ship; but the ship came to a standstill in the middle of the river.

The merchant asked the ship's engineer—version 6 also gives the merchant the name Naikā Banijārā—why the ship would not move any farther. The engineer said, "The ship demands a sacrifice. It will move on only after a human child is sacrificed." Hearing this, the merchant took three lakh rupees and went in search of a child. In the course of his search he came to the village in which Basant lived. As he went along he called out, "Whoever gives me a child shall receive three lakh rupees!" He kept calling, but nobody answered. When he reached the potter's doorway, the potter said, "Yes, I shall give you a boy. I want the money." The merchant gave the potter three lakh rupees, took Basant away and brought him to the ship.

Basant asked him, "Merchant, where are you taking me?"

The merchant replied, "I am taking you to be sacrificed. My ship has stopped in the middle of the river, and I shall offer you as a sacrifice." Hearing this, Basant said, "O merchant, if, once I go there and touch the ship, it begins to move, you will let me go, won't you?"

The merchant answered, "If the ship starts moving, I shall release you."

Basant went into the middle of the current, touched the ship with his hand and said, "Ship, please go on your way, so that my life may be spared."

No sooner had he spoken than the ship set off.

The engineer said to the merchant, "Take him aboard the ship. What if it comes to a halt somewhere else?"

Basant said, "If you had killed me, where would you have brought me from if the ship stopped again?"

The merchant said, "Let him go."

Basant left, walking along the bank of the river, and reached the place where Sīt's wife was weeping.

Basant asked her, "Why are you crying?"

Hearing this, she stopped crying and fell silent.

Basant said, "I, too, have been struck by sorrow. We were two, but after our separation I have become one."

The woman asked, "What is your name, and what was your brother's name?"

Basant replied, "My name is Basant, and my brother was called Sīt."

On hearing this, the woman began weeping again and said, "Your brother has passed away. It is for him that I am grieving." Hearing this—version 7 also uses the name Dil Basant—Basant said, "Then I, too, have no wish to remain alive."

As soon as she heard those words, Sīt's wife died. At that very moment Basant entered the forest, climbed a large tree and prepared to take his own life. Just then a voice from the sky addressed him: "Basant, do not throw away your life. Your brother is alive. Go to the place where his body lies. Cut the little finger of your right hand and sprinkle its blood upon him. Your brother will come to life." Hearing this, Basant climbed down and did exactly as he had been told at the place where his brother's body lay. Sīt rose, saying, "Rām, Rām." The brothers embraced. They set out together. Day gave way to evening, and they stopped beneath a tree.

Sīt said, "Brother Basant, let us stay here. When morning comes we shall set out again."

The two brothers passed the night beneath that tree.

Folktale version 8: At midnight a snake came out of the forest and began climbing the tree. In that tree was a swan's nest with two young swans in it. When the chicks saw the snake, they began crying out. The brothers heard the cries and saw the snake climbing. They thought, "The snake will eat those chicks. If we kill it, their lives will be saved." So they killed the snake.

Meanwhile the mother swan had gone to feed at the pond. She had laid eggs and raised chicks in that nest many times, but not a single young bird had survived. At daybreak she returned from feeding at the pond. Seeing the chicks alive, she was overjoyed. When she offered them food, they turned their faces away and asked, "Mother, how many times have you had young in this tree? Or are we your first chicks?"

The mother said, "No. I have had young here many times, but yours are the only faces I have ever seen alive."

The chicks said, "You would not have seen our faces either if these travellers had not been here. Look down below and see what is lying there."

The swan looked down and saw a snake lying on the ground and two travellers moving about nearby.

The chicks said, "It was these two travellers who killed that snake. Go first and give the travellers something to eat. We shall eat only after they have eaten."

The swan came down and said, "Travellers, unless you eat, my two chicks will not eat either."

The brothers replied, "Mother, love is greater than food. Mother, we too have been battered by circumstances. Who will help us?"

The swan said, "You helped me, and I shall help you. Here, I give you one of my children. This child will help you. When it grows up, it will be able to carry both of you on its wings and fly wherever you wish to go. I bestow this

blessing on you: both brothers shall prosper." The brothers bowed and went on their way. Wherever they stopped, the young swan spread its two wings and shaded them. Several days passed in this way. The young swan grew big enough to carry both brothers on its back.

The swan said, "Brothers, now both of you may climb upon my back. Wherever you tell me to go, I shall carry you."

The two brothers mounted the swan and flew on until they reached the city of Kanchanpur. Outside the city stood a banyan tree. They set up a resting place near it, lived there and went into the city to work. In the evenings they ate near the tree and slept there. All night long the swan watched over the brothers. After some time, Sīt fell in love with Kanchanā, the daughter of the king of Kanchanpur.

The princess was weighed against flowers every day. After she fell in love, her weight began to increase greatly. Word reached the king, who asked why his daughter's weight was increasing. He stationed guards all around the palace. Even so, Sīt would ride the swan into the palace. The entire city was stirred by the question: who was this person secretly entering the king's palace? One day Sīt came as usual. The two sat on a couch, laughing and joking, and both fell asleep. The poor swan returned alone to their resting place. At dawn Sīt and the princess were discovered together in the palace.

The king questioned them about everything, and Sīt told him the whole story.

The girl said, "This is what is written in my destiny, and so it shall remain."

After considering the matter, the king said, "Bring your brother here, and bring the swan as well."

Sīt brought Basant and the swan. The king was very pleased to see the swan.

The king said, "My minister has a daughter. Both brothers shall be married at the same time."

The weddings of both brothers were celebrated with great pomp.

Sīt inherited the kingdom of Kanchanpur, for the king had only one daughter. After some days Sīt said, "Now I shall go to my own city."

The king joyfully bade farewell to the four of them—his daughter, his son-in-law, and the other newly married couple. Sīt and Basant set out for their own country. After several days they reached their city and found it in a desperate condition. They built a dwelling in one corner of their former kingdom and began living there. Sīt's mother and father had both gone blind. Calamity had overtaken them from every direction. One day the parents heard that another king had built a house and was living in a corner of their kingdom. They said, "Come, let us go and meet him."

When they arrived at the doorway, Sīt and Basant immediately recognised them as their mother and father. The two brothers signalled to their wives: "Take these two inside. Bathe them properly, dress them in fine clothes and

give them plenty of good food. Then bring them here and seat them on the dais."

Afterwards Sīt and Basant stood before their parents and said, "Please tell us: how many sons do you have?"

King Maheshwar Singh replied, "I had two sons, but now I have neither. It is the fault of my fate. I do not know whether they are alive or dead. I had ordered them to be killed."

Sīt and Basant said, "No. Both of your sons are alive." As they spoke, tears came to their eyes.

"Father, we are those very sons, Sīt and Basant."

At that moment the king's eyes opened. He clasped the two brothers in his arms, wept and acknowledged his mistake. "Bless you, my children. May your lives be long. May you live for ever."

83. Munnājī's "Māñjh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī" ("Marginalised in the Middle of the Courtyard")

Abstract

"Māñjh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī" is the title of Munnājī's collection of rubāĭyāt and ghazals. Is it influenced by Kabir's paradoxical utterances, or is this simply the nature of the ghazal? It is neither the influence of Kabir's paradoxes nor an intrinsic trait of the ghazal: it is a reality.

Keywords: Munnājī · middle · courtyard · marginalised · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Summary

This chapter presents a critique of the poetry in Munnājī's "Māñjh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī." Munnājī, the middle, the courtyard, marginalisation and the ghazal poet emerge as principal centres of attention. Through examples, quotations and arguments available in the original material, the discussion examines poetic texts, metre, imagery, language and feeling, enabling readers to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

"Māñjh Āṅganme Katiāel Chhī" is the title of Munnājī's collection of rubāʻiyāt and ghazals. To be pushed aside—and that, too, in the very middle of the courtyard! Is this an effect of Kabir's paradoxical utterances, or does it arise from the nature of the ghazal? Neither: it is a reality. Many people like Munnājī have been pushed to the margins; despite their talent, they have become lost to view. But the ghazal poet assumes all the blame himself.

Now I stand pushed aside in the very middle of the courtyard;
By my own ways I have now been set adrift.

That is precisely why he begins to savour the pleasure of tears.

Tears are falling, yet it somehow feels like pleasure;
What a beautiful sorrow of love I have taken upon myself!

He falls into a great pit, and even for that he holds himself responsible:

I learnt no lesson from even the slightest stumble;
That is why I fell into such a deep pit.

Has the ghazal poet, then, forgotten the importance of love? No: everyone needs love.

People of every age need love;
Until death itself, they need care and well-being.

And it is not as though he has only a kos or two to travel. He has a very long way to go; that is why he needs love.

Envy may carry you a kos or two;
To go farther ahead, you need love.

The principle applies everywhere. I had a friend who came first in an examination. He declared, "Either I do not compete at all, or, when I do

compete, I come first." He was not a ghazal poet; had he been one, he might have written as Munnājī does:

Let the clouds hang heavy; it matters little;
If they rain, let them come down as a downpour.

He presents both the difference that a change of perspective makes and the idea of the glass being half full in this form:

Look with your gaze raised, and this world will seem empty;
Lower your gaze, and you will see everything in this world.

The ghazal poet values both criticism and opposition.

Keep yourself on guard against your own partisans;
Do not regard everything an opponent says as bitter.

People are distressed by rising prices; observe the image of a swaying raised watch-platform that he employs to describe them:

Inflation dries up not only the blood but the bones;
People now seem like platforms swaying in the wind.

And consider this paradoxical utterance: the image is new, the feeling timeless.

I lit a bonfire in the summer month;
Sometimes I warmed myself at a fire long extinguished.

What gathering is this? It resembles the politics of printing sponsored letters in a magazine. Consider this rubāʿī:

The heart grew sorrowful at the cries of anguish;
The spectators rose and fled the fighting;
The sponsor merely kept his ears pricked up;
The organisers were exposed by caste factionalism.

But if the subject of floods failed to become part of the Maithili ghazal, we would have to conclude that the ghazal poet had cut himself off from society. That, however, is not the case.

The river's current is still in spate;
People stand watching and waiting on the embankment.

Migration out of Mithila has now diminished. Outsiders have come to treat "Bihari" as synonymous with a labourer or manual worker. The ghazal poet's pen addresses this too.

Bihar's very appearance seems to have changed now;
With fewer labourers, even company owners look like Biharis.

Munnājī's ghazals and rubāʿiyāt flow freely, like a *bamkolā* borne along without restraint. The nature of a *sher*, or couplet, is such that, when it is expressed well, listeners cannot help responding with appreciation. Seeing the way ghazals and rubāʿiyāt are spreading in Maithili, one feels that, even more

than these genres are enlarging their own reach, Maithili itself is benefiting and expanding through them.

Gajendra Thakur

84. Binīt Thākur's "Bāṅkī Achhi Hamar Dūdhak Karj" ("The Debt of My Mother's Milk Remains Unpaid")

Abstract

With a collection of ten songs titled "Bāṅkī Achhi Hamar Dūdhak Karj," Mr Binīt Thākur, a teacher at Pragati Adarsh E. School in Lagankhel, Lalitpur, has come before readers. This is the second book this year to appear in Mithilākṣara as well as Devanagari. I have sent it to Anshuman Pandey for Unicode mapping, since Binītjī gave me permission to send the book by email; I thank him for that. In "Bharal Norme" ("With Tears Brimming"), the poet asks whether anyone ever secured their rights by sleeping. In "Gām Nagarme" ("In Village and Town"), he declares that Madhesis will claim their rights in a democracy; and in "Koro ā Pāṛhi" he asks who, apart from the poor themselves, can understand the blows of poverty, thereby also placing his economic thinking before us.

Keywords: Binīt · Thākur · debt of milk · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Summary

This chapter offers poetic criticism of Binīt Thākur's "Bāṅkī Achhi Hamar Dūdhak Karj." Binīt, Thākur, what remains, our, and the debt of milk emerge as principal points of attention. Through examples, quotations and arguments in the original material, the discussion examines poetic texts, metre, imagery, language and feeling, enabling readers to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

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In the poem "Bharal Norme" ("With Tears Brimming"), the poet asks whether anyone has ever gained their rights by sleeping; in "Gām Nagarme" ("In Village and Town"), he declares that Madhesis will secure their rights under democracy. In "Koro ā Pāṛhi," he asks who other than the poor could understand the suffering poverty brings, and thus also presents his economic thinking. In "Cahundis Amaṅgal" ("Ill Omens on Every Side"), he expresses his environmental concern over the destruction of forests, saying that even the birds' chirping can now scarcely be heard. In "Je Karathi Ghoṭālā" ("Those Who Commit Scams") he strikes relentlessly at corruption, and in "Jāitak Ṭukṛī" ("Fragments of Caste") at the caste system; in "Beṭīk Bhāgyavidhān" ("The Fate Ordained for a Daughter"), his emotions surge. In "Kampyuṭarak Duniyā" ("The World of Computers") and "Aṅgarejiyā," the poet has not

forgotten contemporary life. In the final poem, "Tāl Misrī" ("Palm Sugar Candy"), he speaks with a somewhat satirical tone of a bridegroom's affection for his in-laws, demonstrating his skill in this area too. Although this is the poet's first published work, the range of subjects on which he has composed poetry is extraordinarily praiseworthy.

85. Santosh Kumar Mishra — "Enā Kie..?" ("Why So..?") and "Posput" ("Foster Son")

Abstract

Santoshjī's poetry collection "Enā Kie..?" gives grounds for confidence in the future of Maithili poetry. It brings together twenty-four poems by the young poet. In "Enā Kie..?" Santoshjī foregrounds the problems faced by women, while in "Kālpanik Satya" ("Imagined Truth") he brings out the conflicts of a philosophy of life.

Keywords: Santosh · Kumar · Mishra · Enā Kie · Posput · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Summary

This chapter presents a dramatic-critical study of Santosh Kumar Mishra's "Enā Kie..?" and "Posput." Santosh, Kumar, Mishra, Enā and Kie emerge as principal points of attention. Through examples, quotations and arguments available in the original material, it examines dramatic texts, character arrangements, stage structure and cultural context, enabling readers to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

1

Santoshjī's poetry collection "Enā Kie..?" gives grounds for confidence in the future of Maithili poetry. It contains twenty-four poems by this young poet.

In "Enā Kie..?" Santoshjī raises the problems of women, while in "Kālpanik Satya" ("Imagined Truth") he brings to the fore the contradictions of a philosophy of life. "Bicitra" ("Strange") is likewise concerned with conflict, whereas "Ainā" ("Mirror") takes the poet back to memories of childhood. In "Duvidhā" ("Dilemma"), the poet wonders whether his falling in love—after drowning experience and losing touch with feeling—constitutes a social offence. In "Bhadrak Bali" ("Sacrifice of the Respectable"), the images of sparing neither Sagarmatha nor Makalu and of devouring the Koshi and Karnali make the poem effective. Once the monster killed in hiding; now it kills openly, and the law is in its hands. "Hamar Māykeṁ Buddhiye Nahi Chaik" ("My Mother Has No Sense") reveals a truth of contemporary society: a good person is one who has money; one must pay a bribe to secure a good position and deceive the people in order to become a great leader. In "Nāmī Baniñāke.." the poet feels utterly worthless on hearing the voice of a fine singer. "Annesaṁ Ānand" ("Joy from Grain") satirises society's superstitions. The poet's questions to the bright moonlight and his definition of beauty appear in "Ijoriyā" ("Moonlight"), while in "Māykeṁ Praśna" ("A Question to Mother") he gives voice to a mother's suffering, whose tears exceed the

waters of the sea. "Mātṛbhūmi" ("Motherland") and "Mithilāk Je Chhī Taṁ" are dedicated to Mithila and Maithili. "Hamar Kaniñā" ("My Wife") mixes humour with a discussion of dowry and mismatched marriage. In "Hamar Āś" ("My Hope"), the poet addresses children, new approaches to education and admission based on donations; in "Ham ā Hamar" ("I and Mine"), he makes poems from his portrayal of the good and bad in the whole of society. "Mūlya Abhivṛddhi Kar" ("Value-Added Tax") describes the economy, while "Hamar Mīt" ("My Friend") concerns life and death. Saying that no good people remain in the assembly, the poet expresses his anguish. At every step on the road he sees dangerous snakes, yet in "Jīban" ("Life") the poet's optimism returns.

The poems in this collection are bound up with feeling and memory, and they bring about an inner earthquake. The talent the poet has demonstrated here makes us hope that further collections will appear and shake us awake once more.

2

I have received Santosh Kumar Mishra's collection of short stories, "Posput" ("Foster Son"). This Nepalese writer's book comprises seven stories: "Posput," "Ekṭā Byathā Patrame" ("A Sorrow in a Letter"), "Jakhan Kaniñā Bhelakhin Bimār" ("When the Wife Fell Ill"), "Sipāhī" ("Soldier"), "Ḍākṭar" ("Doctor"), "Bhāgya Appan-Appan" ("Each to Their Own Fate") and "Dāg" ("Stain"). Before considering their plots, it is necessary to discuss other aspects of the volume.

The first noteworthy point is that the book begins with a review of itself. Mr Kālikānta "Tṛṣit" of Depura Rupaiṭhā, Janakpur, has written a comprehensive review. It speaks well of the story writer's intellectual openness that he has given this review its due place; otherwise it would not have appeared in the volume in this form.

The second point is that the book appears to be printed in Devanagari when approached from one side and in Mithilākṣara when approached from the other—and indeed it is. In Maithili this is probably one of the first such experiments witnessed in the twenty-first century.

Let us consider Tṛṣitjī's review first. He writes that an escapist outlook predominates in the stories. He also raises this question: should a literary creator be a neutral presenter or a guide? Should literature favour escapism or become a source of inspiration for struggle?

Regarding "Posput," Tṛṣitjī says that it portrays three generations, but the purpose of incorporating events from the periods of Kings Mahendra and Tribhuvan is not clear.

Of "Ekṭā Byathā Patrame," Tṛṣit says that it describes the passage of time, human helplessness and personal experience.

Tṛṣitjī dismisses the third story, "Jakhan Kaniñā Bhelakhin Bimār," as a sickly story.

"Sipāhī" describes a profession that was once accorded priority in marriage negotiations but has now become undesirable.

Tṛṣitjī calls "Ḍākṭar" the extreme expression of an escapist mentality. In his view, a doctor ought to struggle to save a patient until the very last breath.

"Bhāgya Appan-Appan" is based on the wheel of fate. In "Dāg," actions taken in a moment of impulse, a love marriage contracted at an immature age and subsequently running away with somebody else are all presented as signs of a departure from the right path.

"Posput" is written in an autobiographical style, but its ending comes abruptly, with the role of the foster son and the mother's departure for her natal home.

The second story takes the form of a letter. As in "Posput," its character is named Santosh. This story too ends in great haste, and the author has not managed to convey the sequence of events coherently to the reader.

Similarly, in "Jakhan Kaniñā Bhelakhin Bimār," the author has been unable to make his intended meaning clear.

The character in "Sipāhī" is also named Santosh, though the narrative is not autobiographical. In "Ḍākṭar," the doctor's reward for serving his country is the cancellation of his professional certificate, a development that proves fatal to him. "Bhāgya Appan-Appan" is narrated in the manner of an old folktale: the king sends a prince to survey the kingdom, and the story works well. "Dāg" is narrative in character, but appears to have been written in haste.

Tṛṣitjī has not undertaken a linguistic editing of this short-story collection along with his review, for the volume lacks standardisation. Proofreading, too, has not been done properly. Attempts at standardisation have begun through Videha and Mithila Manthan, and a place has been allotted to the subject in Videha's column on writing practice. The Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore, is also preparing a Maithili style manual. What is needed is for scholars in Nepal to offer their views on the style being developed on the basis of the Maithili Academy's standards, so that it may gain general acceptance.

86. Dūrvākṣata

Abstract

Chapter 22, mantra 22, of the Yajurveda is credited with being the world's first patriotic song. In Mithila, however, the practice of scattering dūrvā grass and unbroken rice grains transformed this verse into the Dūrvākṣata mantra.

The Bihar State Text Book Publishing Corporation Ltd has issued a Class IX textbook titled "Dūrvākṣata."

Keywords: Dūrvākṣata · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Summary

This chapter presents a linguistic study of "Dūrvākṣata." Dūrvākṣata, the zamindar, the mantra, ninth grade and class emerge as its principal concerns. Drawing on examples, quotations and arguments in the original material, the discussion examines linguistic structure, word usage, translation or script arrangement, enabling readers to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

Dūrvākṣata. Chapter 22, mantra 22, of the Yajurveda is credited with being the world's first patriotic song. In Mithila, however, by scattering dūrvā grass and unbroken grains of rice, this verse was turned into the Dūrvākṣata mantra. The Bihar State Text Book Publishing Corporation Ltd has published a Class IX textbook under the title "Dūrvākṣata." This book plainly reveals, in the reviewer's view, a concerted attempt to hold Mithila and Maithili back. Eighteen pages are devoted to teaching the biography of a zamindar who held a Permanent Settlement estate in a district of Mithila! There is a one-and-a-half-page essay, fifty years old, on preserving the Maithili script, but it has no relevance in today's technological age. The essay on the Maithil diaspora is antiquated, and present-day children will find it ridiculous: the meaning of migration, the meaning of being Maithil and the causes of migration have all changed. Is this not a conspiracy to teach children the lessons of servitude? Comparing this book with Class IX textbooks in Hindi, English, Bangla and other languages makes the situation look still more alarming. I appeal to teachers not to teach children the zamindar's biography, and to those setting examination papers not to ask questions from the chapter devoted to that zamindar.

87. The Late Shri Vaidyanath Mishra "Yatri"

Abstract

The Late Shri Vaidyanath Mishra "Yatri" (1911–1998): Yatri was born in 1911 in his maternal grandparents' village of Satlakha, close to his ancestral village of Tarauni. He began studying at the Sanskrit school in his village, later went to Varanasi and Calcutta, and earned the degree of Sahitya Acharya in Sanskrit. He subsequently went to Kalaniya, near Colombo, to study Pali and Buddhism.

Keywords: Late · Shri · Vaidyanath · Mishra · Yatri · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Synopsis

This chapter presents a dramatic critique of the late Shri Vaidyanath Mishra "Yatri." The principal focal points of the discussion are Late, Shri, Vaidyanath, Mishra and Yatri. Drawing upon the examples, quotations and arguments present in the original material, it examines dramatic texts, character organisation, stage structure and cultural contexts, enabling the reader to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

The Late Shri Vaidyanath Mishra "Yatri" (1911–1998): Yatri was born in 1911 in Satlakha, his maternal grandparents' village, near his ancestral village of Tarauni. He began his education in the village Sanskrit school, went on to Varanasi and Calcutta, and earned the Sanskrit qualification of Sahitya Acharya. He then went to Kalaniya, near Colombo, to study Pali and Buddhism. There he took initiation into Buddhism and received the name Nagarjun. Later, however, he returned to the Brahmanical religious fold, undergoing the sacred-thread ceremony again in his village.

Yatri was influenced by Marxism. He began composing verse in Maithili in the closing months of 1929 and started writing in Hindi in 1935. Alongside Swami Sahajanand Saraswati and Rahul Sankrityayan, he participated in the peasant movement; between 1939 and 1941 this involvement took him to several prisons. Many pieces he wrote after Mahatma Gandhi's death were banned. He differed with the Communist Party after its support for China during the India–China war. His participation in the J. P. movement led to his imprisonment during the Emergency. He also wrote children's literature in Hindi; besides Hindi and Maithili, his writing appeared in Bengali and Sanskrit. He received the second Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili in 1969, for the poetry collection *Patrahin Nagna Gachh* (*The Leafless, Naked Tree*). In 1994 he was made a Fellow of the Sahitya Akademi, recognised as a poet in Hindi and Maithili.

Yatri married a twelve-year-old girl when he was twenty. His father, Gokul Mishra, was regarded as uneducated in his community and, in the author's account, was a man of dissolute conduct. Yatri's childhood memories

included the sight of his father raising an axe against his sick, bedridden mother when she pleaded with him to renounce his wayward behaviour. His mother died when he was only six. Another image of his father continued to haunt him: the widowed aunt who had loved him like a mother had nearly died during an abortion of a child conceived by his father outside marriage. What reader of Yatri's Hindi novel *Ratinath ki Chachi* (*Ratinath's Aunt*) could have read it without repeatedly weeping? The conflict between father and son grew so bitter that the son left his young wife in his father's care and departed for Varanasi.

Let the old father reap the fruit of his deeds;
I, his only child, am the fruit of his sin.
May that knowledge cause him no anguish.
Let even others forget my name.
Mother Mithila, this is my last farewell!
(Varanasi, November 1936.)

From Varanasi he travelled to Sri Lanka. With the words "Let the old father reap the fruit of his deeds," Yatri gave voice to his feelings about his father. In 1941 he returned to his wife, Aparajita. That year he wrote two Maithili poems, "Burh Var" (*The Old Bridegroom*) and "Vilap" (*Lament*), had them printed as pamphlets, and sold them to railway passengers. In search of a livelihood, husband and wife travelled throughout India. At his wife's insistence he occasionally returned to Tarauni. Then came 1949, bringing his first Maithili poetry collection, *Chitra*. His wife accompanied him until 1952, after which she settled in Tarauni and Yatri visited from time to time. They had six children, whose care Aparajita carried upon her own shoulders. Yatri suffered from asthma.

When I was studying in Darbhanga, Yatri lived in Khwaja Sarai. I remember that he came to a Maithili event where Communist Party members had taken over the agenda. The following day he withdrew from the proceedings of that disorderly meeting. During his imprisonment under the Emergency he encountered Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh workers; after his release he also wrote against J. P.'s Total Revolution. He published in Maithili under the name Vaidyanath Mishra "Yatri," and in Hindi as "Nagarjun."

"Prithvi te Patram" appeared in *Vaidehi* in 1954 and was included in our matriculation syllabus. Yatri wrote:

"Other festivals may be one thing or another, but Naban lays bare the condition of a landless family. Thus, no sooner does Kartik arrive than Aparajita Devi's veil falls over her face. So deep is the pain that she cannot even raise her eyelids towards anyone! Where has anyone celebrated Naban with grain bought in the market?"

Is Yatri a myth? Has Yatri become a myth? He was principally a Hindi writer; in Maithili he did not write even a tenth of what he wrote in Hindi.

Much of what he did publish in Maithili he translated himself from Hindi. Words and cultural details from Maithili and Mithila seemed obscure, and therefore interesting, to Hindi readers, but there are many shortcomings even there. Consider an example from *Yatri Samagra*: page 220 dates the death anniversary of his paternal aunt to Jeth Sudi Chaturdashi; elsewhere it calls it the first death anniversary; on page 222 it speaks of going, even for a day, to perform the rites as the principal mourner, giving the date of the first observance as Ashadh Badi Tritiya. The original's inconsistent dates are retained here.

The same ailment afflicts other Maithili and Hindi authors. The author maintains that written historical evidence places Gonu Jha between 1050 and 1150, yet Usha Kiran Khan has him debate Vidyapati in her Hindi historical novel *Sirjanhār* (Bharatiya Jnanpith). Virendra Jha dates Gonu Jha to about five hundred years ago, while Taranand Viyogi places him three hundred years ago, in their respective Hindi books published by Rajkamal Prakashan and the National Book Trust. In Vibha Rani's Hindi book about Gonu Jha (Vani Prakashan), Kunal places him under Bhav Singh's reign in the fourteenth century. This happens, the author argues, despite the genealogy registers that place Gonu Jha ten generations before Vidyapati. The vocabulary and culture of Mithila, unfamiliar and therefore fascinating to Hindi readers, become the occasion for Maithili–Hindi writers to spread a great deal of misinformation through ignorance. Communalist writers have even inserted the oppression of a Muslim *tahsildar* into Gonu Jha's stories, although, the author asserts, Muslims did not reside in Mithila during his lifetime.

Balchanma was not included in *Yatri Samagra* because it was regarded as a Hindi work. Its Maithili translation too appears corrupt, as though, after translating half of it, Yatri had run out of time for Maithili. *Navturiya*, however, was included, although that too was originally in Hindi. The editor will have to explain why it was presented as originally Maithili. In Maithili there is a fashion for proofreaders to call themselves editors, and people are reprinting even Grierson's works under their own editorship. In another example, Mohan Bharadwaj, in a collection attributed to Ramanath Jha, printed four English subsections from chapter three of P. C. Roy Chaudhury's *Darbhanga District Gazetteer* as works by Ramanath Jha, apparently believing someone else's attribution. Their written form and grammatical workmanship, the author argues, identify them as Roy Chaudhury's writing. Yatri himself said that he had first written *Balchanma* in Maithili and then translated it into Hindi. Yet he makes no such statement in the Hindi *Balchanma*, instead describing it as Hindi's first regional novel. The author regards this tendency as an affliction still gripping Maithili writers and considers Yatri's contribution to it, intentional or otherwise, a cause for sorrow.

Rajkamal called Yatri a poet of the old school, like Amar and Suman; perhaps Yatri's attention to metre led Rajkamal into this misconception.

The exchange between Ramvilas Sharma and Yatri over whether Maithili is a dialect or a language has little particular significance from the standpoint of linguistics. Ramvilas Sharma was a major Marxist thinker, and more influential than his poetry or essays was his multivolume examination of Indian history. It is linguists such as Subhadra Jha, Ramavatar Yadav, Yogendra Yadav and Sunil Kumar Jha who worked to establish Maithili's status as a language. The exchange between Ramvilas Sharma and Yatri, in the author's judgement, is little more than idle talk.

Chaturanan Mishra and Jagadish Prasad Mandal have both been associated in practice with the Communist movement at the party level. Yet, having read the novels of these two men, I have no hesitation in saying that they do not seem to need the crutch of Marxism upon which Yatri and Dhumketu prop up their novels. The true meaning of Marxism is to be found in the works of Mishra and Mandal. Parties and ideology may never be named, but their writing reveals the essence of dialectical materialism, faith in the significance of life and the employment of a dialectical method. That becomes possible only when a writer studies Marxism deeply, including *Das Kapital*, and spends decades practising Marxism.

And finally, a Sanskrit poem by Yatri:
वासन्ती कनकप्रभा प्रगुणिता
पीतारुर्णैः पल्लवैः
हेमाम्भोजविलासविभ्रमरता
दूरे द्विरेफाः स्ता
यैशसण्डलकेलिकानन कथा
विस्मरिता भूतले
छायाविभ्रमतारतम्यतरलाः
तेऽमी "चिनार" द्रुमाः॥
The golden radiance of spring has doubled with yellow-and-crimson shoots. Bees, mistaking them for the play of golden lotuses, keep their distance. These are the chinar trees whose presence makes us forget the pleasure gardens of the celestial grove upon earth; their fluttering shade shifts in degrees, restless and fluid. I have seen those chinar trees standing steadfast.

88. The Late Shri Harimohan Jha (1908–1984)

Abstract

The Late Shri Harimohan Jha (1908–1984) was born on 18 September 1908 in the village and post office of Kumar Bajitpur, Vaishali district, Bihar,

India. His father, the late Pandit Janardan Jha "Jansidan," was a distinguished Maithili writer and a recognised Hindi poet of the Dwivedi era. Harimohan Jha completed an MA in Philosophy in 1932 and received a gold medal for standing first in Bihar and Orissa.

Keywords: Late · Shri · Harimohan · Jha · 1908 · 1984 · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Synopsis

This chapter presents literary criticism of the poetry of the late Shri Harimohan Jha (1908–1984). Late, Shri, Harimohan, 1908 and 1984 emerge as the principal focal points. On the basis of examples, quotations and arguments available in the original, the discussion considers the poetic text, metre, imagery, language and sensibility, so that readers can understand both its critical organisation and its wider context.

The Late Shri Harimohan Jha (1908–1984)

Born on 18 September 1908 at Kumar Bajitpur (village and post office), Vaishali district, Bihar, India. His father, the late Pandit Janardan Jha "Jansidan," was not only a Maithili writer but also a celebrated Hindi literary figure and poet of the Dwivedi period. Harimohan Jha earned his MA in Philosophy in 1932, winning a gold medal for the highest rank in Bihar and Orissa. He became a lecturer at B. N. College, Patna, in 1933; a teacher at Patna College in 1948; professor and head of department at Patna University in 1953; and a University Grants Commission Research Professor from 1970 to 1975.

His Maithili works include the novels *Kanyadan* (1933) and *Dviragaman* (1943); the story collections *Pranamya Devata* (1945), *Rangshala* (1949) and *Charchari* (1960); and the satire *Khattar Kakak Tarang* (1948). A second edition of the story collection *Ekadashi* appeared in 1987, replacing "Graduate Putohu" with "Dvadash Nidan," which had appeared in *Mithila Mihir* but in none of his earlier collections. "Babak Sanskar," written at Ramanath Jha's request, is also in this collection. His *Khattar Kaka* was published as a Hindi book in 1971. A collection of his separately published and written verse was issued in 1999 as *Harimohan Jha Rachanavali*, Volume 4 (*Poetry*); his autobiography, *Jivan-Yatra*, was published in 1984. *Jivan-Yatra* was the only one of his books published by the Maithili Academy, and it won him a posthumous Sahitya Akademi Award in 1985. In 1999 the Sahitya Akademi published a selection of his stories chosen by Rajmohan Jha and Subhash Chandra Yadav as *Bichhal Katha*. That volume included stories that had not appeared in any of his earlier collections. Many of his works were translated into Hindi, Gujarati, Marathi, Kannada, Telugu and other languages. His published Hindi works include *Nyaya Darshan*, *Vaisheshik Darshan*, *Tarkashastra* (*Deduction*), a Hindi translation from English of Datta and Chatterjee's *Indian Philosophy*, and the edited *Darshanik Vivechanayen*. His English research monograph is *Trends of Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy*.

Just as Vidyapati brought Maithili poetry to its highest summit in the classical period, Harimohan Jha brought modern Maithili prose to a comparable height. His writing is especially distinguished by its humour and satire directed against social and religious rigidity, superstition and hypocrisy. His books remain among the most widely bought and read works in Maithili.

The Complete Works of Harimohan Jha

Let us survey Harimohan Jha's complete writings.

Stories and One-Act Plays

1. Ayachi Mishra (one-act play); 2. Mandan Mishra (one-act play); 3. Maharaj Vijay (one-act play); 4. The Boy's Price (one-act play); 5. A Railway Quarrel (one-act play); 6. The Problem of Organisation (epistolary); 7. A Subscriber to "Rasamayee" (epistolary); 8. Five Letters (epistolary); 9. Conversations on the Dalan; 10. Conversations by the Hearth; 11. Conversations by the Pond; 12. Conversations in the Chaupari; 13. The Authority on Religious Law; 14. The Astrologer; 15. Panditji; 16. The Poet; 17. Transformation; 18. The Duty of the Age; 19. The Maharani's Secret; 20. The Goddess of Seven Colours; 21. Talk of Nine Lakhs; 22. The Theatre; 23. The Pickle Jar; 24. The Cycle of Medicine; 25. The Silk Coverlet; 26. Deception; 27. The Press's Leela; 28. Devi-ji's Sanskar; 29. This Way Flows the River Sursari; 30. A Daughter's Life; 31. A Railway Experience; 32. The Village Social Worker; 33. A Breach of Propriety; 34. Tirhutam; 35. Totma; 36. Pilgrimage; 37. Teaching Ornamentation; 38. Father's Rites; 39. Twelve Diagnoses; 40. The Graduate Daughter-in-Law; 41. Brahma's Curse; 42. The Ideal Meal; 43. A Mark of the In-Laws' House; 44. The Thief of Kalibari; 45. Treatment of Kala-Azar; 46. Exchange; 47. The Police Inspector's Moustache; 48. Philosophical Debate; 49. The Formidable Guest; 50. The Ideal Family; 51. The Shared Ashram; 52. The Resident Son-in-Law; 53. A Sample of Boorishness; 54. The Insurance Agent; 55. The Anglicised Gentleman.

Poetry

1. The Sanatani Baba and the Reformer of the Kali Age; 2. The Auction of the Girl; 3. From *Mithila Mihir*; 4. Dhala Jha; 5. Tea Party; 6. Buchkun Jha; 7. To the Pandits; 8. Nirasan Mama; 9. Fire; 10. A Farewell Song for an English Girl; 11. The Poor Woman's Twelve Months; 12. To Shri Yatri: Maithili Speaks; 13. Saurath; 14. Separation; 15. In Ashoka Grove; 16. Hymn to Patna; 17. Tribute to the Revered Amarnath Jha; 18. Hindi and Maithili; 19. Buchkun Baba's Letter; 20. Light the Glittering Lamps; 21. After Going to Calcutta; 22. Famine; 23. I Like Calcutta Very Much; 24. A Piece of Turnip; 25. Burhanath; 26. To the New Generation; 27. The Pandit and the Englishwoman; 28. A Pandit's Lament; 29. On the Banks of the Ganga; 30. The Wheel of Time; 31. The Glory of High Prices; 32. An Invitation to Savour; 33. To Non-Poetry: Poetry Speaks; 34. I Am a Guest; 35. To the Future Beloved; 36. The Fish Pilgrimage; 37. Sweets; 38. O Rajkamal; 39. To

the Matchmaker; 40. To Panditji; 41. A Young Wife's Problem; 42. Quatrain; 43. Ghazal; 44. Motherland; 45. Praise of Woman; 46. O Mother of the Bride; 47. Salutation to the Motherland; 48. The Death of the Moon; 49. Salutation to Mithila; 50. O Poet, Now Take Up the Hoe!; 51. High Prices; 52. A New Dawn Song; 53. Forty and Seventy-Four; 54. Experimental Poetry; 55. In Memory of the Late Lalit Narayan Mishra; 56. Outpouring; 57. The Final Truth; 58. Maithili Is a Sweet Language; 59. Chhagunta; 60. The Great Vidyapati Festival; 61. Eight Resolutions; 62. Ghutar Kaka; 63. Memories of Vangam–Mahishi; 64. Hymn to Maithili; 65. O Soil of the Motherland; 66. Tell Me, Sir, What?; 67. Kashmir Is Ours; 68. Auspicious Morning; 69. Buchkun Baba's Dream; 70. Hail Vidyapati; 71. Good Wishes; 72. Hymn to the Attendant; 73. Manchan Baba; 74. This Year's Holi; 75. Do Not Deceive; 76. O Labourer! Seeing Your Suffering (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 77. O Labourer! (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 78. Come, Infinite Tender Compassion! (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 79. O Hero, Raise the Plough-Weapon and Sword! (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 80. O Fierce Chandika! (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 81. The Queen of Jhansi (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 82. O Progressive Women's Society (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 83. Beloved, I Am Going to the Other Shore (*Kaviji*, *Pranamya Devata*); 84. Blessed, Blessed Motherland (*Ayachi Mishra*, *Charchari*); 85. Blessed Is This Court of Mithilesh (*Ayachi Mishra*, *Charchari*); 86. O Homeland, Repository of Immortal Fame! (*Ayachi Mishra*, *Charchari*); 87. Why Was Harihar Born? (*The Importance of Fish*, *Khattar Kakak Tarang*); 88. What an Injustice! (*Khattar Kaka's Latest Talk*, *Khattar Kakak Tarang*).
Khattar Kakak Tarang (stories and satires)
Kanyadan (novel)
Dviragaman (novel)
Jivan-Yatra (autobiography)
Dedication of *Kanyadan*:
"To the champions of that society which does not hesitate to give away a daughter as though she were an inanimate object; whose leaders pour thousands upon thousands into the education of boys but do not consider it necessary to buy even a four-paisa slate for a daughter; in which the wife of a BA-qualified husband does not know even A or B; which feels not the least pity in yoking a helpless calf alongside a circus horse to pull the carriage of married life: to the thunderbolt hands of those champions I respectfully, earnestly and fearfully dedicate this book."
Dedication of *Pranamya Devata*:
"To that principal hero of a remarkable character, Bhimendranath, the formidable guest, who borrowed from me seven years ago upon the bank of Kartik Purnima and has not since favoured me with another appearance; whose memorable accomplishments are described at length in the first story; who could rightfully occupy the highest seat among the

'Venerable Deities'; and whose revered relations, upon seeing this book, may establish their rights over it without even having to ask: into his strong, enormous fist this book of extraordinary characters is perforce placed!"
Dedication of *Khattar Kakak Tarang*:
"To the ever-delightful, jest-loving Khattar Kaka, whose intoxicated waves of *bhang* set flowing the pleasures of poetry and learning, whose current washes away Vedas, Puranas and the books of religious law for a while; who blends extraordinary savour and surprise into every remark; who reaches the very hearts of people and tickles them through penetrating satire —'Your own property, uncle, is dedicated to you alone' (*tvadiyaṃ vastu pitṛvya! tubhyam eva samarpitam*)."
Dedication of *Rangshala*:
"To Maya Devi, that marvellous and eternally beautiful conqueror of the three worlds: the ever-young actress who founded this beginningless and endless theatre; the enchanting vina-player who dances the entire animate and inanimate universe on her fingertips; the mysterious woman who gives a glimpse of her bewitching play yet allows no one to touch her; who comes upon the coloured wings of imagination to infuse the artist's art with rasa."

89. Jagadish Prasad Mandal

Abstract

Writing about the Bengal famine of 1942–43, Amartya Sen observes that hundreds of thousands died (1.5 million according to the Famine Inquiry Commission), but none of his own relatives died in it. Likewise, during the 1967 famine in Mithila, the Prime Minister of India was shown how Musahar people survived by eating *bisaṛh*; yet it was not until 2009 that a story about this experience was written. In that year Jagadish Prasad Mandal wrote a Maithili story about *bisaṛh*.

Keywords: Jagadish · Prasad · Mandal · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Synopsis

This chapter presents dramatic criticism concerning Jagadish Prasad Mandal. Jagadish, Prasad, Mandal, Maithili and his work emerge as central concerns. Examining the dramatic text, character organisation, stage structure and cultural context through the source examples, quotations and arguments, it enables the reader to appreciate the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

Writing about the Bengal famine of 1942–43, Amartya Sen observes that hundreds of thousands of people died (1.5 million according to the Famine Inquiry Commission), but not one of his relatives died in the famine. Similarly, during the famine in Mithila in 1967, the Prime Minister of India was shown how Musahar people were struggling against starvation by

eating *bisaṛh*, yet a story on the subject did not appear until 2009. In that year Jagadish Prasad Mandal wrote a Maithili story about *bisaṛh*. The reason for the delay is also clear: because Maithili literature had adopted a one-sided orientation, its writers, like Amartya Sen, may not have been affected as deeply by that immense catastrophe. It is here that Mandal's story rescues the trajectory of Maithili fiction from becoming exclusively one-sided. Every story in this collection is excellent: each fills a vacancy and provides evidence of the renaissance of Maithili literature.

Jagadish Prasad Mandal is a craftsman who compresses his material so effectively that readers are astonished. More importantly, his determination and ability to give his material purpose—in stories, novels, plays and inspirational narratives—establish him at a point from which the history of Maithili literature may be read in two parts: "before Jagadish Prasad Mandal" and "from Jagadish Prasad Mandal onward." All sections of society appear in his narratives, not as ornament but naturally, a veritable upheaval for Maithili literature. One finds no rhetoric of deprivation there. The respect and pride with which he depicts the ways of life of every section of society are extraordinary. His narratives celebrate the dignity of traditional livelihoods against the pursuit of jobs and migration. This carries force because his outlook on writing is the same as his outlook on action, a unity rooted in the distinction of his personal and social life: what he thinks and does is what he writes. Despite novelists such as Yatri and Dhumketu, and story craftsmen such as Kumar Pawan and Dhumketu, Maithili remained distant from ordinary people. The cadences of Maithili have long attracted people beyond Mithila; within those cadences Mandal's socially engaged literature, representing society, culture and language, will bring change not merely to Mithila's social sphere but also to its economy. Five of his novels, one play, more than two dozen stories and more than a hundred inspirational tales for children and adolescents have been published electronically in *Videha*. Reaching Maithili speakers scattered throughout the world, they have stirred them deeply and filled a gap in Maithili literature.

90. Premshankar Singh

Abstract

Maithili Language and Literature: The Twentieth Century: This collection of essays, treatises and criticism by Premshankar Singh discusses various welcome and unwelcome aspects of Maithili literature in the twentieth century and the first decade of the twenty-first. Unwelcome developments arise because political, social, economic and cultural problems, transformations and processes of integration sometimes contradict one another. Earlier contexts for Maithili

literature are discussed in *Maithili Bhasha aur Sahitya* (*Maithili Language and Literature*).

Keywords: Premshankar · Singh · literary criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Synopsis

This chapter presents dramatic criticism concerning Premshankar Singh. Premshankar, Singh, Maithili, discussion and literature emerge as central concerns. The examples, quotations and arguments in the source are used to examine dramatic texts, characters, staging and cultural contexts, enabling the reader to understand both its critical organisation and its broader context.

Maithili Language and Literature: The Twentieth Century: Premshankar Singh's collection of essays, treatises and criticism discusses the pleasant and unpleasant dimensions of Maithili literature during the twentieth century and the first decade of the twenty-first. The unpleasant dimensions arise because the processes of political, social, economic and cultural change, as well as integration, sometimes contradict one another.

The older context of Maithili literature is described in *Maithili Bhasha aur Sahitya*. "Folk Ballads" discusses folk narrative while highlighting Manipadma's contribution to the genre. "Folk Theatre" offers a detailed account of Maithili folk drama. "The Twentieth Century: The Golden Age" surveys a hundred years of Maithili literature. "Traditional Drama" considers conventional plays in Maithili and those translated into Maithili. "Jivan Jha, the Agent of Social Change" identifies the new subjects and techniques Jivan Jha introduced into Maithili dramatic literature. "Harimohan Jha's Influence on Later Writers" is a critical essay on Harimohan Jha. "Jai Kant Mishra, Vigilant Sentinel of the Maithili Movement" is based on his contribution. "Memoir Literature" examines reminiscence through Manipadma's recollection of meeting him. "Amar's One-Act Plays: Social Reality" treats Amar's work in that form, while "Mayanand's Radio Craft" surveys Mayanand Mishra's work in the corresponding genre. "Chetana Samiti and the Stage" describes the creative work undertaken by Chetana Samiti.

Across these essays, attention is paid to all the essential elements of criticism: an aesthetically informed observation of truth and the work of art; the creation of institutions and the present need for reforms based on the economic and social interests of the entire community, without distinctions of religion, race or sect; discussion of the proper place of women's writing and children's literature; attempts, wherever possible, to identify mediocrity; and the refusal to allow prejudice or hatred against any person to determine evaluation. One finds no one-line pronouncements here, but sustained examination.

91. Against Darkness: "Hāthī Chalae Bazār" — Arvind Thakur and Devshankar Naveen

Abstract

Arvind Thakur and Devshankar Naveen: Arvind Thakur (1954–) and Devshankar Naveen (1962–) are two short-story writers who have written Maithili fiction beyond the familiar figures of Kaniyā Kākī and Buccī Dāi, though both have written little. Arvind Thakur has written particularly little: to date, each author has published only one collection, Arvind Thakur's Against Darkness (Anhārak Virodhme) and Devshankar Naveen's Hāthī Chalae Bazār. Thakur's strength lies in his political-economic narratives; Naveen presents himself through the remarkable breadth of his vocabulary.

Keywords: Against · Darkness · Hāthī · Chalae · Bazār · Arvind · Devshankar · Naveen

Abstract · Synopsis

This chapter offers literary criticism of the short-story writings considered under 'Against Darkness' and 'Hāthī Chalae Bazār' by Arvind Thakur and Devshankar Naveen. The title words Against, Darkness, Hāthī, Chalae and Bazār form principal points of reference. Drawing upon the examples, quotations and arguments present in the source, the analysis examines subject matter, characters, structure, language and social meanings, enabling the reader to understand both the critical organisation of the work and its larger context.

Arvind Thakur and Devshankar Naveen: Arvind Thakur (1954–) and Devshankar Naveen (1962–) are two fiction writers who move beyond Kaniyā Kākī and Buccī Dāi in writing Maithili stories, though neither has written much. Arvind Thakur has published very little indeed: each has only one story collection so far, Against Darkness by Arvind Thakur and Hāthī Chalae Bazār by Devshankar Naveen. Thakur's strength is in his political-economic stories, while Naveen comes before us with the immensity of his linguistic vocabulary. The stagnation of the Maithili short story is being diminished somewhat, but many essential aspects remain untouched because writers produce so little and remain idle—subject to that particularly Maithil inertia. Naveen brings back the same plot repeatedly: for example, in "Ṛṇkhauk" and "Ijot," there is mention of a daughter-in-law killing her father-in-law, along with similar recurrences, suggesting that several stories have been fashioned out of a single plot. There is also the plot in the latter half of "Ussar Jamin" ("Barren Land"), which the writer has not used as effectively as he might. I mention that latter plot because Maithils have lived through the experience it describes, and on precisely such a basis Kumar Pawan wrote the unforgettable story "Paiṭh" (published in Antikā), a story capable by itself of making his reputation imperishable, just as Chandradhar Sharma Guleri's "Usne Kaha Tha" sustained his. Arvind Thakur, for his part, writes stories that interweave the social, political and economic so thoroughly that they attempt to fill a vacancy in Maithili fiction. But he writes far too seldom: the reader remains thirsty and the vessel remains unfilled.

Against Darkness — "Khissā Siyār-Yār": Ramnarayan Maharaj is a former MLA and former chair of the Government Publications Committee. At the time of a scandal, Ramadhar Pandey, the chief minister's brother and an MLA, had protected him. Garibdas Azad, district committee general secretary, spent many years among the Socialists and now belongs to the Mahasabha Party; even his son has taken to robbing trains. Shaligram Rai and Lakhan Yadav belong among the insolent and self-important. A meeting is under way. Political commentary emerges in several paragraphs through the mouths of Rajnath Jha and Jibachh Mandal. Sadanand Vidrohi is a young associate of Tofan Singh, the self-appointed leader of the opposition to the Mahasabha Party; he lost his right hand in a bomb explosion while accompanying Singh. His expressions of regret, Pandeyji's manoeuvre to install Raghubansh Mandal as district committee vice-president on the argument that backward classes deserve representation, and his silence when confronted by Chaudharyji's prestige all form part of the spectacle. Rajmangal Shrivastava and Satish Singh Parmar—the "thirty-six-babu Kshatriya," in the terminology of the swaggering men—enter the scene. Parmar is all-powerful in the fifty-one-member Dhela Committee. The pair of Shrivastava and Parmar is notorious: when apart they abuse one another, but they stay together. Former block president Shanichar, known as "Shani," is a tireless consumer of ganja and other intoxicants; current youth president Ganesh Gurmaita makes a profession of petitions. Chatterjee-da is on the telephone from Patna, contemplating a front with Chaubeyji against Chaudharyji and Pandeyji. When Parmar entangles Shani and Gurmaita in conversation, someone deliberately sets them at loggerheads, and someone else comes to their rescue. Jatashankar Malik, better known as Makhan Babu, is a "wrench that fits every nut and bolt," to use the same boastful vocabulary. He calls out to Parasmani Chaudhary to draw attention to himself and responds to one respectful greeting with three of his own. His son, Bauka Babu, a member of a communalist party, has taken his car, and his jeep is broken. Since he has to arbitrate a dispute in the Dusadh settlement, he must summon a rickshaw. He keeps eating chyawanprash and has taken homoeopathic treatment in Raghopur. Sita Babu is block president of the Mahasabha Party, described as Makhan Babu's "daughter-in-law" in the swaggerers' idiom. Subodhnarayan Singh, known as Subodhji, is a former MLA and former district president of the Mahasabha Party: to supporters he is the district's Gandhi, to opponents a Natwarlal, and to the swaggerers "Mundhubara." His way of life is simple and his manner courteous. He is devoted to Chief Minister Shivadhar Pandey, Ramadhar Pandey's brother. Yet his growing closeness to Chaudharyji earns him punishment: Shivadharji asks him to withdraw his party candidature. Rajiv Sharma suffers from the mistaken belief that politics can be practised without deceit, intrigue, lies or betrayal. He speaks out in the wrong places, for which the arrogant men call him a biter. When Subodhji says that a telephone call came from Shivadhar Babu and therefore he had to withdraw his name, Sharma responds that they will pull down the whole nest of these scoundrels and hooligans. Ramsogarath Mandal, a freedom fighter, is also present, but he has declined the freedom-fighter's pension. When someone broaches it, he

says, "Go on, son, go and teach that lesson to Sunnar Thakur, who got hold of a freedom-struggle pension by shaving ministers' hair and beards." At that moment a new disturbance begins; someone has again stolen a march. Makhan Babu gets out of a large car and places a garland around Ramadhar Pandey's neck. Suddenly everyone is garlanding everyone else; equally suddenly the speeches begin. Meanwhile, in Ramsogarath Mandal's dream, terrifying black shapes encircle the golden dream on every side.

"Piyāsal Pāni" ("Thirsty Water"): Ramcharan works as a cultivator; the ploughing now falls to his son Lakhna. Lakhna's gauna, the ceremony marking the bride's arrival after marriage, brings the woman from Narayanpur to the household. The author, or narrator, goes to see the bride's face and is overwhelmed by her beauty. Lakhna's aunt from Beriya teases him, and he leaves. One day the Narayanpur bride begins to touch the narrator's feet. In rice transplantation, weeding, harvesting or other field labour she has no equal. One morning, while it is still dark, he sets off to supervise harvesting; beside a grafted mango tree her eager lips leave their marks on his cheek, forehead and throat. Just then the voice of Sarjugba, the household servant, rises out of the darkness. Cursing that enemy and invoking a thunderbolt from God upon him, the Narayanpur woman moves away, submerged in thwarted desire, longing and resentment. Rumour spreads that a witch has possessed her. She tears off her clothes. Motiya Dusadh drinks liquor, the offering to Barham Baba, becomes a ritual exorcist, and breaks seven green switches upon her body. He claims to have driven the witch to the peepal tree in Haridwar's cremation ground. The Narayanpur woman runs away. Lakhna is married again, but this time the narrator sends eleven rupees for the ceremonial viewing of the bride through someone else. Ramcharan is delighted by reports of the new bride's promise, while Lakhna beats his own head because he is impotent. The Narayanpur woman was a Lakshmi—innocent, unfortunate and abandoned.

"Anhārak Virodhme" ("Against Darkness"): There is shouting and commotion. The writer or narrator goes outside and comes to Alauddin, a Muslim vegetable seller. Alauddin recounts what happened. Janardan Chaudhary is his friend; in the same neighbourhood Bikua abused the friend's brother. The brother came to complain of Bikua's misconduct, calling out "Brother!" But Bikua struck him, while the women of his household started abusing the visitor. They even tried to turn the dispute into a Hindu–Muslim issue. What honour could such a neighbourhood still claim? At precisely that moment, brilliant electric light breaks through the breast of the darkness that has spread its frightening shadow everywhere, illuminating the surrounding distance.

"Ḍhāčhā—1992" ("The Structure—1992"): The story takes the form of a letter by the narrator, who acknowledges that everything he has written was written under the pressure of circumstances. He has recently had jaundice and has lain with his tongue parched; sunlight, dust and smoke distress him. There is another strange illness: his body burns intensely and small rashes begin to rise on his skin. Once, returning from Saharsa, his scooter broke down. A mechanic promised to repair it in half an hour, then scattered all its parts and

kept him there for four hours. Back in Supaul he went to Dr Das's clinic. Drops of homoeopathic medicine worked, but only after hours. The same had happened once when he was returning from his in-laws' home: separation from his wife, bone-chilling cold and a whistling wind. A gathering brings Professor Rajendra, Dr Mukherjee and Principal Jha of the K. K. Institute of Madology together. Professor Rajendra tells Mukherjee that he will pay the five-rupee consultation fee, but the medicine must be free—physicians' samples. Mukherjee says the medical representatives pay him no attention, so they will have to go to Dr Das. Then comes the destruction of the Babri Masjid structure in Ayodhya. The narrator's trembling, burning, blotches and swelling return. There is no immediately discernible physical cause, yet his body has suffered the event.

"Mūs" ("Rat"): A man runs a pharmacy. The new drug inspector has taken a five-hundred-rupee ceremonial payment during Durga Puja. The shop seems to have ground to a halt; Anuj sits there. Will a Bhumihar concoct schemes, or conduct business? There is an old bank loan and five years of unpaid household electricity bills. His wife's eldest brother is an accountant in Nagpur, with a good job and a healthy wife. If only he were a magician who could say "gili-gili-phu," or if only Aladdin's lamp were in his hands! A rat has tormented him, even at mealtimes, but now he feels not the slightest anger. The town has been raised from sub-divisional to district headquarters, and land prices have risen. He could sell the land and clear his debts. Sleep gives way to transparent bubbles and rats of many shapes and forms: gnawing, fighting, dancing, loving, reading books and playing rummy. Later a giant bubble appears, and plague comes from the rats. Industrious rats make burrows in which snakes live. He wakes with a start, looks at the portrait of his late father and asks whether he too will use the wealth amassed by his forebears like a snake. He takes a hoe and begins clearing weeds from the garden bed.

"Prajātantra Parikathā" ("A Fairy Tale of Democracy"): There has been one murder and two household robberies. Kamal Kumar Sharma reads the report, which seems censored. It does not mention that the murdered Dr K. P. Bhagat was retired and charged only nominal fees. The robbers had entered his home pretending to be poor patients and their relatives. How could the reporter, against whom a black-marketing and adulteration case is pending, have written that the police station stood barely a hundred paces from the doctor's house and the police officer's residence scarcely sixty or seventy paces away? From the doctor's place the gang went to the home of Vikram Prasad Verma, a recently retired teacher decorated with the President's Medal. They robbed his home and had food prepared, which they ate. Vikram Babu's brother Gajanan Babu managed to slip away to the superintendent of police, yet nothing came of it. People gathered outside the main gate of the hospital grounds. The Chemists and Druggists Association under Madhuresh Kishore Dwivedi led the protest. What if something should happen to children returning from school? The speakers appeared: broker Ishwar Chaudhary; procurer Murlidhar Agrawal; a journalist who sold petrol adulterated with kerosene; municipal chairman Buchnu Babu, who traded in stolen goods; and the black-marketeer Seth Kanakdharimal, a sixty-year-old husband to a

twenty-five-year-old wife who, through the munim's generosity, had borne four children. His panting over the loudspeaker sounded like a minor storm. There was Gyannath Singh, president of the Bar Association, who defended murderers and robbers; the ganja-smoking petty leader Krishnanand Tiwari, who proposed a free plan to convert the flood-stricken region into Disneyland; and the fair-skinned Dr Dharamchand Sahay, whom those in the know called D.C.S.—an acronym for drink, girls and a coarse abuse—delivering his fevered words. The crowd became leaderless. People insisted that the mass itself, rather than a delegation, should speak directly to the authorities. Meanwhile an "old fox" held forth on the terrace about international problems. A motorcyclist attempted to take control of the crowd: he was the newest recruit of a communalist party. Madhureshji took precautions. A new, rough-hewn slogan, newly born, attracted Kamal's attention and that of others. Then came Pradip Krantikari, who had supposedly abandoned engineering studies out of devotion to social service—or had been expelled for drunkenness and rape. The sub-divisional officer's jeep was attacked. Pradip Krantikari shouted that "the bastard" wanted seven thousand rupees for a coal licence: "Did you see the storm?" Madhureshji had gathered others, including Gajendraji, a lecturer at the local college, and Madhavji and Krishnamohanji of the traders' association. Without mishap the crowd reached Gandhi Chowk and Jayaprakash Chowk. Then Goldiya, who sat at the sweetshop and played cricket—careful, even there, about how the ball was provided; when it met the bat it went for six, otherwise it was clean-bowled—saw a government vehicle and shouted: "Hit it! Set it on fire!" Some charged towards it, but the driver sped away. At Nyay Chowk, also called Nawab Chowk, soldiers of the Vishwa Hindu Sena had installed Bajrangbali because a statue of blindfolded Justice holding scales could not be placed there. A sign naming it Bajrang Chowk was erected. At that time Dalit officers predominated in the administration and wanted the intersection named Ambedkar Chowk; so, in the story's satirical account, they "arrested" Bajrangbali and carried him to the police station, where, it is said, he is worshipped even today. Since the intersection adjoins the municipal offices it is now called Municipality Chowk. The sub-divisional officer returned with a force and they began swinging their batons together. Policemen chased people for a considerable distance. The crowd then began hurling stones in return. The police fled in disorder. An inspector with a Hitler-style moustache arrived, but men from Bargāȟi had driven away in his vehicle. The sub-divisional officer and others hurried into the jeep and made their escape. Kamal searched the scene with his eyes. Goldi argued with him; Amjad Ali seized Kamal's arm, and a dozen people stood between an enraged leopard and a thick-headed buffalo. People outside the political and social factions did not know the art of flattering the powerful. Why engage with them at all? The demand now was for the release of two arrested companions, but the officers, concerned for their own safety, were unwilling. The DSP with his hoodlum's haircut spoke with coarse insolence. Madhureshji remarked, "Whether you are determined to depart without a mark on you, or whether only thoroughgoing supporters of Jayaprakash surround you..." An agreement was reached to

release the detainees. Not a human being—or even a crow—was in sight. Had Kurukshetra fallen into such silence after the Mahabharata war? A group of children was entering the field to play cricket.

"Atha Girgiṭ Kathā" ("Now the Tale of the Chameleon"): Mukkan Babu, that is Mukund Jaiswal, is a dealer with a Public Distribution System shop. A police sub-inspector with the same name had once arrived, causing considerable amusement. Ramlakhan Poddar, B.Sc. Honours, son of Kishan Poddar the tea-and-paan seller, topped his examinations but wore out his shoes seeking a job. The municipal instrument for measuring the social atmosphere would find seventy-five per cent cowardly respectability, twenty per cent friendship founded on self-interest and five per cent miscellaneous viruses. The police outpost occupies a warehouse-like building, with a liquor shop adjoining it. One day the men unexpectedly come face to face: Mukund emerging from the police post and Ramlakhan from the liquor shop. After their quarrel, the police sympathise with Mukund, while customers emerging from the liquor shop side with Poddar. Ramlakhan is arrested, and the following morning his father secures his release by making offerings of flowers and leaves to the police. Mukkan Babu then gathers sixteen people, forms an Anti-Intoxication Citizens' Forum and stages a sit-in at the liquor shop. The sixteen comprise seven paternal and maternal cousins of various kinds, two ploughmen, an operator of a paddy-husking machine, three notorious friends, and two delinquent sons of the family priest. But Poddarji arrives with thirty-six people to protect his rights. When the commander of the anti-intoxication forum rushes forward with a staff, the others are carried bodily away; a sequence of blows and scuffles ensues. Subrata Mukherjee, a specialist in swaggering violence, calls it gang warfare. Then municipal elections are announced. The virus of self-interested friendship reveals its colours before Shivaj Rigalk. Mukkan Babu becomes chairman and Poddarji vice-chairman. Peace returns to the town.

"Ayyāśī" ("Indulgence"): A man dreams of pleasure in sitting with a friend, but his wife asks for ten rupees for vegetables and says the groceries can come tomorrow or the day after. He sets out for his friend's house, refusing to listen to his son. He passes Patel Chowk and reaches Mahatma Gandhi Chowk with twenty rupees in his pocket. A rickshaw-puller rests with the canopy raised. He gets in; along the way he buys a two-rupee cigarette for his friend, his favourite magazine Mor for twelve rupees, and gives the rickshaw-puller four rupees. The breeze from his friend's fan affords some relief. The remaining two rupees mock him: the vegetables for the household, and his son's books and notebooks. When he returns, his body is drenched in sweat. Seeing his wife's angry, red eyes, one would think he has returned after a bout of debauchery.

"Baikbā-Phorbā": The underlying news is that the petrol of an already inflamed atmosphere has been shown the matchstick of private interest. The incident concerns Prakash Agrawal's firm, "Vriddhichand Bhanwarlal Cloth Store." With its outstanding credit approaching a lakh, the firm hires Sikandar Jha, motherless, unruly, son of the late Raghunath Jha and an eighth-standard failure, to collect debts. One day he approaches Ramchand

Marar, whose son Kaleshwar Marar—now using Yadav as his surname—had had a three-thousand-rupee three-piece suit made four years earlier. The father refuses liability for his son's debt. On the road, while stopping for paan at Munna Thakur's shop, Sikandar meets Kaleshwar Yadav, accompanied by relatives and family. Where Sikandar himself had once acted as a tough, Kaleshwar now does. A demand for repayment turns into a fight. Sikandar pins him down by the chest. Sikandar's old associates gather and thrash Kaleshwar's relatives. The next day a procession for Backward-Caste Unity attacks the cloth store, smashing its glass. Armed men arrive and rain down blows with sticks. People flee wherever they can squeeze through. Looting and disorder spread. A series of glimpses follows. Scene one: district president Purushottam Mandal speaks in his party's office, a building with eighteen rooms and two large halls. A goodwill procession is planned. Chiranjeev Singh, president of the party youth wing and Mandalji's ardent disciple, becomes furious: "You too are from a small caste; naturally you will side with them!" He storms out. Scene two: a thatched house. Dhanilal and Ramnarayan discuss what Baikba-Phorba means. What does Matru know? After silence, someone begins singing the Ālhā. Scene three: the tea-and-snack shop of Comrade Ramsevak Sahu. There is debate about Vidyanivasji's speech, declaring that caste is no such thing at all; a youth calls him mad and walks away. Scene four: children playing during the school lunch break. "This grass-and-thatch house is mine, and I shall be a Yadav. The shop belongs to Birju, and he will be a Brahmin. We shall quarrel. Lallu, Mohan, Naren and Bablu will come and set fire to my house. Then Suresh will become the leader and Vinod the policeman. Suresh will tell the officer to get both our house and shop rebuilt and to catch those responsible. Suresh will make us shake hands and become friends." The game of Baikba-Phorba lasts the whole lunch period.

"Viṣ-Pān" ("Drinking Poison"): Gopalji sits restlessly on a chair in the lawyers' room. At the courthouse gate a parrot-owning astrologer sits beneath a banner advertising mamira collyrium to improve eyesight. From the court veranda orderly Ramesar Mandal, son of Jagesar Mandal, shouts. A litigant promises his lawyer the remaining fee at the next hearing, but the lawyer is digging his ear with the blunt end of a pen. Gopal overhears. One day at a paan shop, Chaturanan had come with a stick and beaten him until he fell. Neniya, his father's old servant, arrived and struck Chaturanan, who nevertheless escaped. The sixty-year-old mother of Ramprasad from Marauna was first to inquire after Gopal. Gopal was taken to hospital. Chaturanan, too, came there seeking treatment and an injury report; someone recognised him and chased him away with a length of drainpipe. Everyone called Chaturanan a habitual criminal, but Gopal had tried to reform him; he had now become a Bhasmasura, a destroyer of his benefactor. The police extracted money from Chaturanan and he stayed at home. Hearing dates kept being set in Gopal's case, and his X-ray plate vanished from the hospital. After three years the evidence began, followed by cross-examination: had he been wearing a full-sleeved shirt that day, had it a collar and pocket, what was its colour; how long and what sort of stick had struck him? The lawyer was his friend, but one day

the sharpness of his tone was unmistakable: "You see, litigants have paid us; naturally we must attend to their work first." No testimony was recorded that day, and the judge entered an adverse observation on the file. Chaturanan settled matters for three thousand rupees, with the suggestion that Gopal might pay more if he could. An offer had also reached the lawyer-friend through counsel for the opposing party. At Gopal's request, proceedings to transfer the case began. But it was transferred to a court connected by kinship to Shilbhadra Jha, Gopalji's political rival, under whose protection Chaturanan now lived. Gopal signs a compromise petition: a surrender likened to General Niazi's surrender with a hundred thousand troops in the India–Pakistan war.

Hāthī Chalae Bazār: This short-story collection is arranged in three sections. The first, Mūldhan ("Principal"), contains stories of ordinary length, roughly two thousand words each—the form called the "short story" in English. In Maithili, however, the "short story" or laghu-kathā is often written within a single page, and a collection of those is placed in the second section, Byāj ("Interest"). The last section, Lorhā-Bicchā, contains stories of different lengths that the author evidently considers somewhat weaker. Yet after reading them, one finds that many from that last section merit inclusion under Principal and Interest, while quite a few in Principal and Interest would fit better in Lorhā-Bicchā.

Mūldhan ("Principal") — "Anhār" ("Darkness"): The road passing through Lauhar village has been paved. Government jeeps travel along it, and flocks of goats bleat on the way to be offered in sacrifice at Mahishi Ugratara. Children emerge from houses whose eaves almost touch, amid wheat and straw. Tetar Musahar used to work as a ploughman for a household in Sarauni village and was cutting straw for Ramanand Singh. The wheel of Kulwant Singh's truck ran over his boy. The village headman arrived and took six thousand rupees from Sardar Kulwant Singh, saying that two thousand would be given to Tetar. Tetar's whole body trembled: how was he to count so many five-rupee notes? Tetar tried to console his wife from Baluaha: "As long as you and I are alive, will there not be more children?"

"Tax Free": Chalittar works at a brick kiln. Instead of six and a half rupees he receives five; the overseer keeps one and a half. But a budget was passed only yesterday: an article formerly costing four rupees and seventy-five paise will now cost seven rupees and seventy paise. The candidate Chalittar had voted for has come to the inspection bungalow, so Chalittar goes to him. Before the election, he says, he could at least eat half a stomachful; now he cannot manage even that. But the leader, now a minister, rebukes him: "How many garments and cloths we distributed! We got televisions and the BDO made tax-free! Yet no one is grateful." Police throw Chalittar out, landing punches and slaps upon him. From whom is he to learn what "tax free" means?

"Babūr" ("The Acacia"): A drought-stricken man has died and must be taken on his last journey. He had only one son, Udba. The father had long felt close to the gentlemen of the village. Udba sets off towards the Brahmin quarter: even if each man contributed just one piece of wood, there would be a heap. Instead he hears taunts: "Dogs and crows ate the flesh of his forefathers, yet

these drought victims now want a tree for cremation!" Udba sends word to bring the corpse to the embankment. Meanwhile he cuts and splits the acacia growing on government land and builds a pyre. He lights it. Panditji arrives and remarks that a funeral pyre should not be made of acacia; Udba should have put a torch in the dead man's mouth and floated him down the river. Furious, Udba snatches the pandit's almanac and throws it into the fire. This acacia, he says, is the sandalwood for the likes of you.

"Sambandh" ("Relationship"): Sugiya and her husband Jibachh live beside the crossroads and run a makeshift stall selling puffed rice, sweets and sugar confections. Between the evening meal and sleep they lie in one another's arms and talk. If the old woman had lived just this one more year, their happiness might not have ended. Sugiya is pregnant. Today, while eating rice and parwar, she hears cries as her husband is being strangled by members of the extended kin group. She rushes there, but they attack her with an axe too. At the police station the sub-inspector is busy settling matters with a tractor-owner. He demands a two-hundred-rupee fee for registering her case. Jibachh has only sixty rupees in his shirt pocket. Sugiya goes to the goldsmith to sell her bangles and neck ornament, but he takes advantage of her desperation and offers too little. By the time she raises the money, Jibachh has died. The sub-inspector says he died without making any statement; perhaps Sugiya was involved with another man and had arranged for gangsters to murder her husband. He locks her in the police cell and sends word to his quarters that he will not be coming home that night.

"Antim Behośī" ("The Final Unconsciousness"): The narrator's bhauji, Lalita Mishra, is the wife of Professor Samaresh Mishra, head of the Chemistry Department. They were first teacher and pupil, then lovers, then husband and wife. There is an age gap of at least ten years. They have three children: Sushma, fourteen; Madhuri, twelve; and Shwetabh, ten. Bhauji is pregnant for the fourth time, because the hunger of the body is powerful. Her daughters are ridiculed at school and tell their mother, "Our heads split with shame at the mockery; will you never stop bearing children?" She attempts an abortion but gets no help from Samaresh Bhai. Haunted by her daughters' words and her swollen belly, she even thinks of striking it with the end of a rolling pin. She faints. Had her fourth pregnancy come fourteen years after the first child, would her daughter not have prayed to the gods, as Shipra did? Shipra, a student at the narrator's college, had welcomed a brother born when she was seventeen. The doctor's expression does not look reassuring. Bhauji's baby is now in the narrator's arms. Bhauji has left this world and its intrigues. With the twenty-six-hour-old infant, he enters Samaresh Bhai's quarters. Bhauji's ten-year-old son talks to him joyfully, without waiting for replies. Bhauji regained consciousness only long enough to leave a message: the English-medium school has turned her two daughters into Chandis; they will not let this baby live. "You are now its mother and father." The narrator is lost in thought. The sisters have gone to school. How is he to perform the funeral rites and have the ten-year-old son put on mourning garments?

"Ussar Jamin" ("Barren Land"): Tejo Babu is the narrator's kinsman, a paternal relative known to the younger people as Phul Kaka. In the days of his

strength he had satisfied his lust, by consent or coercion, with women working in his fields. Now he is father-in-law to two daughters-in-law and one son-in-law. He used to imitate the narrator's squint until, through doing so, the eyeball of his own right eye seemed to disappear beneath the upper lid. Looking now at his grandchildren—their faces like the flat bowl of a roof tile, lips like old pointed gourds, potato-shaped noses, catlike eyes and cheeks like bursts of Holi powder—he repents. Arbitrators assemble to divide the property of his sons Ram and Lakshman. Ram has a daughter, and a father of daughters grows old early; Lakshman has a son. Lakshman's wife from Simraha realises that the elder brother will have to pay for one daughter's marriage next year and another soon afterwards. She looks for a pretext to divide the family. The arbitrators, a surveyor and a labourer to weigh the grain arrive. The man who once mediated other families' quarrels now faces arbitration in his own. Everything is divided, but there is only one threshing floor and one well: the floor is broken up and the well filled in. Yet how can one break or fill in one's parents? The father goes with Ram and the mother with Lakshman. Both are left like heaps of dung and dust. The Simraha daughter-in-law sees no benefit in allotting two bighas of land from the common property to the elderly parents. When rice pudding is made in the younger son's home, a spoonful or two falls even on the old mother's leaf plate; yet eating alone wounds her heart. Phul Kaka has become a philosopher: why should a barren cow, sterile land or a lame ox expect care and maintenance?

"Pavan Pul" ("The Bridge of Air"): The narrator has taken his Intermediate Science examination, with only the practical left. He returns to the village in the interval, unwilling to place a greater burden on his low-paid father. He was in Saharsa just three days earlier. His younger sister Saroj lies on her deathbed. She is eldest among his three younger sisters, yet three years younger than he. Married at ten and sent to her husband's home at thirteen, she was brought back on a carrying pole after six months. Her husband is an ignorant good-for-nothing. The narrator used to tease him by asking when the automatic watch and the English Raleigh bicycle he demanded had been manufactured; Saroj was punished even for that teasing. In the physics practical the narrator could not measure the radius of curvature of a convex lens, but by the following morning Saroj had crossed beyond that curved boundary forever. His middle paternal uncle, whom he calls Babu, loves the narrator and Saroj more than life itself. Yet people of their own community refuse to help carry the corpse. The narrator's aunt points out the absurdity: the four women of the lineage are left to weep and console one another, while voices whisper through cracks and corners that the girl died just as she reached maturity and will become a witch galloping through the neighbourhood all night. At the funeral feast Ranganath Mishra asks who will rise first: there are only twenty-one Brahmins, one short of twenty-two. The narrator's younger uncle sits down himself. The narrator seizes Mishra by the arm and makes him stand: "Get out at once, or I shall not spare a single shoe! Let the butcher go. Give his leaf plate to the pig belonging to Bhikho Dom."

"Caritra" ("Character"): Gautamji is an ardent Communist, a Karna Kayastha

by caste. He smokes bidis, useful for maintaining a proletarian image, and his moustache has curled into points. He is a Maithil settled in Calcutta, with three daughters. When arranging a daughter's marriage, he takes his lover along to inspect prospective grooms. One match is unsuitable because the family is Ambashtha Kayastha; in another the prospective groom's Karna Kayastha father has a Christian widow as his second wife. The story of Adelina enters at this point. When a headmaster remarks on Adelina, a newly appointed teacher says that Adelina would be only two or three years older than the headmaster's youngest daughter, thereby silencing him. The story ends when Gautamji's middle daughter gives her father a sharp rebuke.

"Ijot" ("Light"): The narrator is playing chess with Madhukarji. As they play he discusses not only Madhukarji's dishonest moves on the board but also his dishonesty in life. When he calls Madhukarji the pupil of a sinful guru, Madhukarji becomes angry: "I am the one who will teach your wife to beat your parents, bring disgrace upon your house, and refuse to let your sister and brother-in-law live with you!" Their conversation over the chessboard exposes Madhukarji's peculiar talents: causing disruption at weddings, applying archery like Ekalavya to seal a dog's mouth, and tutoring the narrator's wife in absurd and disruptive behaviour. He has even told the narrator's sister's parents-in-law: "He has money to buy land in Delhi, but none to give his sister and brother-in-law?" The narrator's wife was already wielding "five brooms and five beatings" against her parents-in-law; Madhukarji has added another five blows on account of the sister. The poor woman has since died. Finally the narrator picks up Madhukarji's knight, returns it to its old square and urges him to bring honesty into his moves.

"Hāthī Chalae Bazār": Bhavani Dai was her father's beloved daughter. After her mother's death she was brought up and married. When her husband Kalyan secured a qualification, her father died on hearing the happy news—of joy, the tale says. Then Bhavani Dai bore a son, and her husband died. In seeking the insurance payment and a compassionate appointment, she encountered two kinds of official. The young manager of the insurance company was courteous and settled everything within minutes. The officer at her husband's workplace, however, was depraved. The story ends with the rebuke that his daughter Gita delivers to her father.

"Chhaguntā": Bairagiji, Ramadhin Pandey "Bairagi," has a son who has become a college professor. The tale gathers pace when that son is kidnapped. Bairagiji has withdrawn twenty-five thousand rupees from his provident fund and kept it ready, only for the money to disappear too. His elder son Arun is also missing. The narrative then turns to Dukhmochan, son of a freedom fighter who refused a pension. Dukhmochan is a criminal figure, revealing his tendencies in high school when he sexually assaulted the daughter of a neighbour disadvantaged by caste and poverty. There followed highway robbery, snatching and other crimes. Disliking the leadership of Bhagatji, an MLA from a lower caste, he implicated him in a case and became a fugitive politician, with the support of people of his own caste. His surrender and show of strength are announced for a certain date. The gathering is exclusively of his caste, "like wheat of a single colour," and includes men and women of all

ages. Dukhmochan becomes a powerful man. Arun wages a righteous war against him, killing his thuggish henchmen while Dukhmochan himself enjoys life in Delhi and Patna.

"Gati" ("Course"): Jagat Jha is the village cat. The village is Mohanpur, with people of every caste except Bhumihars and Doms. Bhumihars have no place in its customary social organisation, but Doms do: hence the Dom comes from Chandrayan. After being pawned for two years with Dasai Pasi, he is again allotted to Bhikho Dom of Mohanpur. Manohar Dhanuk's daughter Chanarma also lives in the village. She knows Brahminical pretensions well. After marriage she returns from her husband's home at Bakour, leading her husband along: she did not know the demons of Bakour, whereas all the dogs of Mohanpur knew her. She then has four daughters. Jagat Jha incites Anil Singh, son of T.T., who is coming from Tarbanni, by asking whether Chaniya has paid him what she owed. A brawl and a police case follow. Eventually both sides discover Jagat Babu's true character and join together against him.

"Madhyāntar" ("Intermission"): Jagattarini and Alka Devi are co-wives, but neither shows the slightest trace of jealousy. Alka has two children. Taranand came from a poor family and Alka from a prosperous one; they had studied together. When Taranand passed the civil-service examination, however, dowry considerations led to his marriage with Jagattarini, dark as a stone image but lovely in conduct. Through the efforts of the supposedly unattractive Jagattarini, Alka too comes into the household. Then Mira, the uneducated wife of Manohar, a distant younger male relative of Jagattarini, arrives. The bonds of Mira's marriage begin to weaken, and the lawyers enter. Mira wins her case, but Manohar's lawyer and Mira's own lawyer exploit her sexually. Jagattarini then offers Mira reassurance and trust.

Byāj ("Interest") — "Kirāyā" ("Rent"): Gulabbagh in Purnia is a centre of commercial sex. Amid cries that some lepers have been rubbed and made to swell and that for ten rupees one may obtain "your own companion and your father's companion," a voice addresses the narrator: "The bastard has neither strength in his pocket nor in his loins."

"Patan" ("Fall"): In floodwater, Chanma tries to recover the contents of Jholi Misar's trunk. A snake raises its hood as if saying, "I am not more venomous than you."

"Usās" ("Breath"): A widowed woman from Thana has a sick daughter, Doli. She stops going to the mansion to work, and the master twists ten rupees out of her. Her mother tells Doli the tale of the Rohu fish who suffered oppression and was killed when a kabai fish lodged a thorn in its throat. Doli asks, "Is there no kabai fish for this master?"

"Otghan": A servant, Musba, is refused leave for the Jitiya festival. The mistress applies Jitbahan's ritual oil generously to her own child's head, while Musba hopes for a single drop. In a dream his mother asks why he has come away: "There, your mistress would have served the otghan meal with curd made from pure milk." He answers that the offering oil never even escaped the hand of that Simbakshi woman; what otghan meal could she have served him?

"Jāgriti" ("Awakening"): A crow perches at the fork of a royal road, before the Parliament House shining as though bathed in milk, like a young woman

emerging from a milk bath. The familiar tale is repeated: a dog asks a crow to sing so that it can eat the bread. But the crow holds the bread in its claw and answers, "Living in a hollow, how will you hear the songs of the outside world?"

"Jāti" ("Caste"): Kameshwar Babu has a sexual relationship with Sugni, who works in his house. Many years later he looks lustfully at Sugni's daughter Sarasatiya and asks about her. Sugni replies that the girl is indeed grown, but she is wondering what caste of boy to seek for her marriage: one of her own caste, or one of Kameshwar Babu's.

"Mahāmantrī" ("General Secretary"): Vinod, with an MA in economics, becomes trapped in the manoeuvres of Agriculture Minister Pandeyji. His paddy-husking business suffers, and the funds allotted by Pandeyji are siphoned away above his head.

"Ekodiṣṭa" ("The Funeral Offering"): The father, known as Malik Baba, has died. His eldest son Madhu Bhai, in anger also called Madhukanta, is enraged when the invited man fails to attend and cares nothing for the guest's official obligations. He asks why Sunara was not invited instead. Madhu Bhai hurries in and overhears the remark.

"Bhārat" ("India"): Gandhi's statue falls. Passers-by respectfully bow before it but none takes the trouble to lift it. A beggar continues begging beside the fallen statue despite receiving fewer alms, hoping that when Gandhi Baba rises he can tell him of the country's condition.

"Kṛtajñatā" ("Gratitude"): Susmit, Akshayvat and Rakesh are walking and talking. Thanks to Professor Ramnarayan Singh, someone had received good examination marks. The professor meets the narrator, and the secret emerges that the marks were given in return for the present of a fine umbrella.

"Visangati" ("Incongruity"): The narrator is a medical representative. Natho Bahin needs medicine for stomach pain, Tejo Kaka for a case of ringworm, and Awadhesh Bhai pills to stimulate his appetite. But Subelal, the ploughman, whose son is five years older than the narrator, calls him "master." He does not want medicine for a bad stomach: he cannot obtain as much food as his stomach could digest. He asks whether there is a medicine that would reduce hunger.

"Boin" ("Wages"): Jugo Marar's wife Dhoraywali crosses the threshing ground at Kinkar Babu's home without wages; her son Lalmohra works there too merely for food. With the narrator's help she is granted an old-age pension. Yet her employer will not pay wages for the two days he sends her away from work. At the block office an official accepts her papers without taking money. She concludes that her business must not have been done: how could any poor person's work be accomplished without wages or payment?

"Pahicān" ("Recognition"): During a funeral rite involving the dedication of a tree, a calf dies from being struck by the wooden implement.

"Anuttarit" ("Unanswered"): Dina Babu's sexual appetite is met with a question from Budhni, his ploughman's daughter: "In this salwar frock, do I look like his eldest sister?"

"Yogyatā" ("Qualification"): Rafiq Sahib opens a school and, in judging a young woman's qualifications, asks her age. The story is not powerful.

"Uddeśya" ("Purpose"): The chief minister demands the education minister's resignation in connection with the proposed prohibition of cheating in examinations.
"Bodh" ("Understanding"): A king sees the serpent king's wife having intercourse with a water-creature and hears her question: "Is a grain of virility not greater than a mountain of noble lineage?"
"Mol-Jol" ("Bargaining"): On Panki Road in Daltonganj, during the death rites for Bharat Babu's mother, a Brahmin receiving milk and oil demands a hundred and fifty-one rupees, then another fifty, and is still dissatisfied. A Brahmin beggar offers to drink the milk and sesame mixture for that sum instead.
"Mūlya" ("Value"): Manorama studies for her PhD under Lakhan Babu. When he proposes a love affair, she replies, "With the very eyes that have seen you as so great a figure, how can I see you naked?"
"Āsthā" ("Faith"): During an emergency, Panditji proposes to perform the cow-gift rite with eleven rupees, sesame, kuśa grass, barley and unbroken rice instead of an actual cow. When the narrator questions this substitute, the priest says, "Is it a human being? It is an animal—an animal!"
"Antim Abhilāṣ" ("Last Wish"): Asked for his dying wish, Madar Das says he longs to eat potato curry and rice.
"Sarokār" ("Concern"): Phul Babu dies. Just then dollars arrive for a poem published in America, prompting Madaneshwar Babu to ask how much it will amount to in Indian currency.
"Pratibaddhatā" ("Commitment"): Ramsharanji's understanding of Indian poverty and the exploitation of women is so lucid from reading foreign authors. Lalita has been engrossed in his work for a month. But when a discussion of feminism exposes the difference between his professed theory and conduct, and Lalita rebukes him, he declares feminism a weapon wielded by impertinent young women to subdue men.
"Jogār" ("Arrangements"): After Kumar Gandharva's death, two newspaper reviewers in JNU's Kaveri Hostel dispute who should write about him. One claims to have been writing articles on Gandharva since the day the musician first became ill; he tells the other to write a poem instead.
"Piṇḍadān": Chakradhar Babu refuses to pay Jhingur Jha for land taken after Jha's mother's death. On the night before Chakradhar sets off for Gaya to offer piṇḍa to his ancestors, he dreams: do not dispossess the living; the dead will settle themselves.

Lorhā-Bicchā — "Bhūkh" ("Hunger"): Ramkisna was the narrator's childhood companion. Now Ramkisna grazes cattle while the narrator is a professor. On Holi, when the narrator attempts to put colour on him, Ramkisna says colour cannot cling to filthy, soiled clothes. His stomach has been burning for four days.
"Mahagī Unmūlan" ("Eradication of High Prices"): Manindra walks along a Patiala road with his father and family. Everyone except speakers of one language is being hacked down like radishes and turnips. He survives, and later comes at Holi to play with His Excellency, using foul-smelling water rather than the colours of the corpses, because the water is cheaper.

"Kasāī" ("Butcher"): Surenma's land lies in the way of making Bilat Singh's field rectangular, but Surenma will not consent. He is beaten. The sub-inspector demands money; even an appeal to the superintendent of police achieves nothing, because the sub-inspector secured his position by paying a bribe to that very officer.
"Dahej" ("Dowry"): The narrator's younger sister refuses to return to her husband's house for the gauna unless she takes along a matchstick and a tin of kerosene.
"Pīṛhīk Dvandva" ("Conflict of Generations"): The wheel of fate, differences between Saheb Rai and Ramdev Rai, and the change of a father's name from Ramdev to Chaturbhuj Rai.
"Pahine, Āi, ā Kālhi" ("Yesterday, Today and Tomorrow"): The narrator asks Gonu Baba a question; Gonu replies that people will weep in the past, present and future over the stick, rice and revolver ball.
"Pratiphal" ("Consequence"): The consequences of Bharati and Sharad's scientific theory. Methods for determining the birth of a son have reduced the number of girls; now men wage wars over women.
"Uparāg" ("Eclipse"): Kamo Jha's first wife came from Dibra, his second from Murli. The second wife had a son and three daughters. A snake bites her son Niranjan—is it because he worshipped by touching the Shiva liṅga, or because of the first wife's supposed witchcraft? Kamo's father Musai Jha had an illicit relationship with his daughter-in-law from Dibra. At the death of the wife from Murli, people ask her son Indradev to light the funeral pyre. She discloses a secret: "You are not his son; you are his ... his younger brother!"
"Kou Kāhū Magan" ("Each Content in His Own Way"): The narrator and companions are out walking when Chaudharyji finds a ten-rupee note on the road. Whose money can it be? If a hollow appears in one place, must some other place not rise higher?
"Ṛṇkhauk" ("Debtor"): Nilesh comes from a poor family. After he gains an education, village people pressure his father into arranging his marriage. His wife is such that she beats his father. Nilesh decides to marry a woman of another caste; a neighbour says, "He is a debtor: he will die before he has repaid the debt to his father."

Story: Among the educated middle class, those who study Maithili from Class IX through the undergraduate and postgraduate levels, whether as a language or their mother tongue, develop affection for it. The arrival of Maithili on the internet has rekindled affection for the mother tongue. Maithili books, including textbooks produced by government institutions, have remained difficult to obtain; the internet has intervened in this situation, but only to a limited extent. Consequently a sense of inferiority has entered Maithili writers (a superiority complex is itself a form of inferiority), and literature has begun to stand on a raised mound of self-regard. Controversies are manufactured, with literary debate reduced to charges and countercharges. Husbands and wives, districts and regions, fathers and sons have begun creating favourable environments for themselves: stories and poems are written for prizes through blackmail and black marketing. Yet even literary works awarded the Booker or the Nobel Prize do not necessarily endure

forever. Many are remembered, many are forgotten, and readers eventually determine their value. In Maithili, however, generations pass and, in the absence of readers, spouses, fathers and sons, regional factions and now circles of poets and fiction writers determine merit by blackmail. Because the internet's intervention is still limited, fine literature, creative literature and writing beneficial to society do not come forward or are not produced. Will you encourage poets and fiction writers who stay in the news by provoking disputes because they are practising blackmail—or humanistic poets and fiction writers who remain among the dust and earth? Only when you make that choice will you be able to infuse life into what appears to be a purposeless Maithili literature.

Supplementary Discussion

Arvind Thakur and Devshankar Naveen: Arvind Thakur (1954–) and Devshankar Naveen (1962–) are two fiction writers who move beyond Kaniyā Kākī and Buccī Dāi in writing Maithili stories, though neither has written much. Arvind Thakur has published very little indeed: each has only one story collection so far, Against Darkness by Arvind Thakur and Hāthī Chalae Bazār by Devshankar Naveen. Thakur's strength is in his political-economic stories, while Naveen comes before us with the immensity of his linguistic vocabulary. The stagnation of the Maithili short story is being diminished somewhat, but many essential aspects remain untouched because writers produce so little and remain idle—subject to that particularly Maithil inertia. Naveen brings back the same plot repeatedly: for example, in "Ṛṇkhauk" and "Ijot," there is mention of a daughter-in-law killing her father-in-law, along with similar recurrences, suggesting that several stories have been fashioned out of a single plot. There is also the plot in the latter half of "Ussar Jamin" ("Barren Land"), which the writer has not used as effectively as he might. I mention that latter plot because Maithils have lived through the experience it describes, and on precisely such a basis Kumar Pawan wrote the unforgettable story "Paiṭh" (published in Antikā), a story capable by itself of making his reputation imperishable, just as Chandradhar Sharma Guleri's "Usne Kaha Tha" sustained his. Arvind Thakur, for his part, writes stories that interweave the social, political and economic so thoroughly that they attempt to fill a vacancy in Maithili fiction. But he writes far too seldom: the reader remains thirsty and the vessel remains unfilled.

Against Darkness — "Khissā Siyār-Yār": Ramnarayan Maharaj is a former MLA and former chair of the Government Publications Committee. At the time of a scandal, Ramadhar Pandey, the chief minister's brother and an MLA, had protected him. Garibdas Azad, district committee general secretary, spent many years among the Socialists and now belongs to the Mahasabha Party; even his son has taken to robbing trains. Shaligram Rai and Lakhan Yadav belong among the insolent and self-important. A meeting is under way. Political commentary emerges in several paragraphs through the mouths of Rajnath Jha and Jibachh Mandal. Sadanand Vidrohi is a young associate of Tofan Singh, the self-appointed leader of the opposition to the Mahasabha Party; he lost his right hand in a bomb explosion while

accompanying Singh. His expressions of regret, Pandeyji's manoeuvre to install Raghubansh Mandal as district committee vice-president on the argument that backward classes deserve representation, and his silence when confronted by Chaudharyji's prestige all form part of the spectacle. Rajmangal Shrivastava and Satish Singh Parmar—the "thirty-six-babu Kshatriya," in the terminology of the swaggering men—enter the scene. Parmar is all-powerful in the fifty-one-member Dhela Committee. The pair of Shrivastava and Parmar is notorious: when apart they abuse one another, but they stay together. Former block president Shanichar, known as "Shani," is a tireless consumer of ganja and other intoxicants; current youth president Ganesh Gurmaita makes a profession of petitions. Chatterjee-da is on the telephone from Patna, contemplating a front with Chaubeyji against Chaudharyji and Pandeyji. When Parmar entangles Shani and Gurmaita in conversation, someone deliberately sets them at loggerheads, and someone else comes to their rescue. Jatashankar Malik, better known as Makhan Babu, is a "wrench that fits every nut and bolt," to use the same boastful vocabulary. He calls out to Parasmani Chaudhary to draw attention to himself and responds to one respectful greeting with three of his own. His son, Bauka Babu, a member of a communalist party, has taken his car, and his jeep is broken. Since he has to arbitrate a dispute in the Dusadh settlement, he must summon a rickshaw. He keeps eating chyawanprash and has taken homoeopathic treatment in Raghopur. Sita Babu is block president of the Mahasabha Party, described as Makhan Babu's "daughter-in-law" in the swaggerers' idiom. Subodhnarayan Singh, known as Subodhji, is a former MLA and former district president of the Mahasabha Party: to supporters he is the district's Gandhi, to opponents a Natwarlal, and to the swaggerers "Mundhubara." His way of life is simple and his manner courteous. He is devoted to Chief Minister Shivadhar Pandey, Ramadhar Pandey's brother. Yet his growing closeness to Chaudharyji earns him punishment: Shivadharji asks him to withdraw his party candidature. Rajiv Sharma suffers from the mistaken belief that politics can be practised without deceit, intrigue, lies or betrayal. He speaks out in the wrong places, for which the arrogant men call him a biter. When Subodhji says that a telephone call came from Shivadhar Babu and therefore he had to withdraw his name, Sharma responds that they will pull down the whole nest of these scoundrels and hooligans. Ramsogarath Mandal, a freedom fighter, is also present, but he has declined the freedom-fighter's pension. When someone broaches it, he says, "Go on, son, go and teach that lesson to Sunnar Thakur, who got hold of a freedom-struggle pension by shaving ministers' hair and beards." At that moment a new disturbance begins; someone has again stolen a march. Makhan Babu gets out of a large car and places a garland around Ramadhar Pandey's neck. Suddenly everyone is garlanding everyone else; equally suddenly the speeches begin. Meanwhile, in Ramsogarath Mandal's dream, terrifying black shapes encircle the golden dream on every side.

"Piyāsal Pāni" ("Thirsty Water"): Ramcharan works as a cultivator; the ploughing now falls to his son Lakhna. Lakhna's gauna, the ceremony marking the bride's arrival after marriage, brings the woman from Narayanpur to the household. The author, or narrator, goes to see the bride's

face and is overwhelmed by her beauty. Lakhna's aunt from Beriya teases him, and he leaves. One day the Narayanpur bride begins to touch the narrator's feet. In rice transplantation, weeding, harvesting or other field labour she has no equal. One morning, while it is still dark, he sets off to supervise harvesting; beside a grafted mango tree her eager lips leave their marks on his cheek, forehead and throat. Just then the voice of Sarjugba, the household servant, rises out of the darkness. Cursing that enemy and invoking a thunderbolt from God upon him, the Narayanpur woman moves away, submerged in thwarted desire, longing and resentment. Rumour spreads that a witch has possessed her. She tears off her clothes. Motiya Dusadh drinks liquor, the offering to Barham Baba, becomes a ritual exorcist, and breaks seven green switches upon her body. He claims to have driven the witch to the peepal tree in Haridwar's cremation ground. The Narayanpur woman runs away. Lakhna is married again, but this time the narrator sends eleven rupees for the ceremonial viewing of the bride through someone else. Ramcharan is delighted by reports of the new bride's promise, while Lakhna beats his own head because he is impotent. The Narayanpur woman was a Lakshmi—innocent, unfortunate and abandoned.

"Anhārak Virodhme" ("Against Darkness"): There is shouting and commotion. The writer or narrator goes outside and comes to Alauddin, a Muslim vegetable seller. Alauddin recounts what happened. Janardan Chaudhary is his friend; in the same neighbourhood Bikua abused the friend's brother. The brother came to complain of Bikua's misconduct, calling out "Brother!" But Bikua struck him, while the women of his household started abusing the visitor. They even tried to turn the dispute into a Hindu–Muslim issue. What honour could such a neighbourhood still claim? At precisely that moment, brilliant electric light breaks through the breast of the darkness that has spread its frightening shadow everywhere, illuminating the surrounding distance.

"Ḍhāĉhā—1992" ("The Structure—1992"): The story takes the form of a letter by the narrator, who acknowledges that everything he has written was written under the pressure of circumstances. He has recently had jaundice and has lain with his tongue parched; sunlight, dust and smoke distress him. There is another strange illness: his body burns intensely and small rashes begin to rise on his skin. Once, returning from Saharsa, his scooter broke down. A mechanic promised to repair it in half an hour, then scattered all its parts and kept him there for four hours. Back in Supaul he went to Dr Das's clinic. Drops of homoeopathic medicine worked, but only after hours. The same had happened once when he was returning from his in-laws' home: separation from his wife, bone-chilling cold and a whistling wind. A gathering brings Professor Rajendra, Dr Mukherjee and Principal Jha of the K. K. Institute of Madology together. Professor Rajendra tells Mukherjee that he will pay the five-rupee consultation fee, but the medicine must be free—physicians' samples. Mukherjee says the medical representatives pay him no attention, so they will have to go to Dr Das. Then comes the destruction of the Babri Masjid structure in Ayodhya. The narrator's trembling, burning, blotches and swelling return. There is no immediately discernible physical cause, yet his

body has suffered the event.

“Mūs” (“Rat”): A man runs a pharmacy. The new drug inspector has taken a five-hundred-rupee ceremonial payment during Durga Puja. The shop seems to have ground to a halt; Anuj sits there. Will a Bhumihar concoct schemes, or conduct business? There is an old bank loan and five years of unpaid household electricity bills. His wife’s eldest brother is an accountant in Nagpur, with a good job and a healthy wife. If only he were a magician who could say “gili-gili-phu,” or if only Aladdin’s lamp were in his hands! A rat has tormented him, even at mealtimes, but now he feels not the slightest anger. The town has been raised from sub-divisional to district headquarters, and land prices have risen. He could sell the land and clear his debts. Sleep gives way to transparent bubbles and rats of many shapes and forms: gnawing, fighting, dancing, loving, reading books and playing rummy. Later a giant bubble appears, and plague comes from the rats. Industrious rats make burrows in which snakes live. He wakes with a start, looks at the portrait of his late father and asks whether he too will use the wealth amassed by his forebears like a snake. He takes a hoe and begins clearing weeds from the garden bed.

“Prajātantra Parikathā” (“A Fairy Tale of Democracy”): There has been one murder and two household robberies. Kamal Kumar Sharma reads the report, which seems censored. It does not mention that the murdered Dr K. P. Bhagat was retired and charged only nominal fees. The robbers had entered his home pretending to be poor patients and their relatives. How could the reporter, against whom a black-marketing and adulteration case is pending, have written that the police station stood barely a hundred paces from the doctor’s house and the police officer’s residence scarcely sixty or seventy paces away? From the doctor’s place the gang went to the home of Vikram Prasad Verma, a recently retired teacher decorated with the President’s Medal. They robbed his home and had food prepared, which they ate. Vikram Babu’s brother Gajanan Babu managed to slip away to the superintendent of police, yet nothing came of it. People gathered outside the main gate of the hospital grounds. The Chemists and Druggists Association under Madhuresh Kishore Dwivedi led the protest. What if something should happen to children returning from school? The speakers appeared: broker Ishwar Chaudhary; procurer Murlidhar Agrawal; a journalist who sold petrol adulterated with kerosene; municipal chairman Buchnu Babu, who traded in stolen goods; and the black-marketeer Seth Kanakdharimal, a sixty-year-old husband to a twenty-five-year-old wife who, through the munim’s generosity, had borne four children. His panting over the loudspeaker sounded like a minor storm. There was Gyannath Singh, president of the Bar Association, who defended murderers and robbers; the ganja-smoking petty leader Krishnanand Tiwari, who proposed a free plan to convert the flood-stricken region into Disneyland; and the fair-skinned Dr Dharamchand Sahay, whom those in the know called D.C.S.—an acronym for drink, girls and a coarse abuse—delivering his fevered words. The crowd became leaderless. People insisted that the mass itself, rather than a delegation, should speak directly to the authorities. Meanwhile an “old fox” held forth on the terrace about international problems. A motorcyclist attempted to take control of the

crowd: he was the newest recruit of a communalist party. Madhureshji took precautions. A new, rough-hewn slogan, newly born, attracted Kamal's attention and that of others. Then came Pradip Krantikari, who had supposedly abandoned engineering studies out of devotion to social service—or had been expelled for drunkenness and rape. The sub-divisional officer's jeep was attacked. Pradip Krantikari shouted that "the bastard" wanted seven thousand rupees for a coal licence: "Did you see the storm?" Madhureshji had gathered others, including Gajendraji, a lecturer at the local college, and Madhavji and Krishnamohanji of the traders' association. Without mishap the crowd reached Gandhi Chowk and Jayaprakash Chowk. Then Goldiya, who sat at the sweetshop and played cricket—careful, even there, about how the ball was provided; when it met the bat it went for six, otherwise it was clean-bowled—saw a government vehicle and shouted: "Hit it! Set it on fire!" Some charged towards it, but the driver sped away. At Nyay Chowk, also called Nawab Chowk, soldiers of the Vishwa Hindu Sena had installed Bajrangbali because a statue of blindfolded Justice holding scales could not be placed there. A sign naming it Bajrang Chowk was erected. At that time Dalit officers predominated in the administration and wanted the intersection named Ambedkar Chowk; so, in the story's satirical account, they "arrested" Bajrangbali and carried him to the police station, where, it is said, he is worshipped even today. Since the intersection adjoins the municipal offices it is now called Municipality Chowk. The sub-divisional officer returned with a force and they began swinging their batons together. Policemen chased people for a considerable distance. The crowd then began hurling stones in return. The police fled in disorder. An inspector with a Hitler-style moustache arrived, but men from Bargāȟi had driven away in his vehicle. The sub-divisional officer and others hurried into the jeep and made their escape. Kamal searched the scene with his eyes. Goldi argued with him; Amjad Ali seized Kamal's arm, and a dozen people stood between an enraged leopard and a thick-headed buffalo. People outside the political and social factions did not know the art of flattering the powerful. Why engage with them at all? The demand now was for the release of two arrested companions, but the officers, concerned for their own safety, were unwilling. The DSP with his hoodlum's haircut spoke with coarse insolence. Madhureshji remarked, "Whether you are determined to depart without a mark on you, or whether only thoroughgoing supporters of Jayaprakash surround you..." An agreement was reached to release the detainees. Not a human being—or even a crow—was in sight. Had Kurukshetra fallen into such silence after the Mahabharata war? A group of children was entering the field to play cricket.

"Atha Girgiṭ Kathā" ("Now the Tale of the Chameleon"): Mukkan Babu, that is Mukund Jaiswal, is a dealer with a Public Distribution System shop. A police sub-inspector with the same name had once arrived, causing considerable amusement. Ramlakhan Poddar, B.Sc. Honours, son of Kishan Poddar the tea-and-paan seller, topped his examinations but wore out his shoes seeking a job. The municipal instrument for measuring the social atmosphere would find seventy-five per cent cowardly respectability, twenty per cent friendship founded on self-interest and five per cent miscellaneous viruses. The police

outpost occupies a warehouse-like building, with a liquor shop adjoining it. One day the men unexpectedly come face to face: Mukund emerging from the police post and Ramlakhan from the liquor shop. After their quarrel, the police sympathise with Mukund, while customers emerging from the liquor shop side with Poddar. Ramlakhan is arrested, and the following morning his father secures his release by making offerings of flowers and leaves to the police. Mukkan Babu then gathers sixteen people, forms an Anti-Intoxication Citizens' Forum and stages a sit-in at the liquor shop. The sixteen comprise seven paternal and maternal cousins of various kinds, two ploughmen, an operator of a paddy-husking machine, three notorious friends, and two delinquent sons of the family priest. But Poddarji arrives with thirty-six people to protect his rights. When the commander of the anti-intoxication forum rushes forward with a staff, the others are carried bodily away; a sequence of blows and scuffles ensues. Subrata Mukherjee, a specialist in swaggering violence, calls it gang warfare. Then municipal elections are announced. The virus of self-interested friendship reveals its colours before Shivaj Rigalk. Mukkan Babu becomes chairman and Poddarji vice-chairman. Peace returns to the town.

"Ayyāśī" ("Indulgence"): A man dreams of pleasure in sitting with a friend, but his wife asks for ten rupees for vegetables and says the groceries can come tomorrow or the day after. He sets out for his friend's house, refusing to listen to his son. He passes Patel Chowk and reaches Mahatma Gandhi Chowk with twenty rupees in his pocket. A rickshaw-puller rests with the canopy raised. He gets in; along the way he buys a two-rupee cigarette for his friend, his favourite magazine Mor for twelve rupees, and gives the rickshaw-puller four rupees. The breeze from his friend's fan affords some relief. The remaining two rupees mock him: the vegetables for the household, and his son's books and notebooks. When he returns, his body is drenched in sweat. Seeing his wife's angry, red eyes, one would think he has returned after a bout of debauchery.

"Baikbā-Phorbā": The underlying news is that the petrol of an already inflamed atmosphere has been shown the matchstick of private interest. The incident concerns Prakash Agrawal's firm, "Vriddhichand Bhanwarlal Cloth Store." With its outstanding credit approaching a lakh, the firm hires Sikandar Jha, motherless, unruly, son of the late Raghunath Jha and an eighth-standard failure, to collect debts. One day he approaches Ramchand Marar, whose son Kaleshwar Marar—now using Yadav as his surname—had had a three-thousand-rupee three-piece suit made four years earlier. The father refuses liability for his son's debt. On the road, while stopping for paan at Munna Thakur's shop, Sikandar meets Kaleshwar Yadav, accompanied by relatives and family. Where Sikandar himself had once acted as a tough, Kaleshwar now does. A demand for repayment turns into a fight. Sikandar pins him down by the chest. Sikandar's old associates gather and thrash Kaleshwar's relatives. The next day a procession for Backward-Caste Unity attacks the cloth store, smashing its glass. Armed men arrive and rain down blows with sticks. People flee wherever they can squeeze through. Looting and disorder spread. A series of glimpses follows. Scene one: district president

Purushottam Mandal speaks in his party's office, a building with eighteen rooms and two large halls. A goodwill procession is planned. Chiranjeev Singh, president of the party youth wing and Mandalji's ardent disciple, becomes furious: "You too are from a small caste; naturally you will side with them!" He storms out. Scene two: a thatched house. Dhanilal and Ramnarayan discuss what Baikba-Phorba means. What does Matru know? After silence, someone begins singing the Ālhā. Scene three: the tea-and-snack shop of Comrade Ramsevak Sahu. There is debate about Vidyanivasji's speech, declaring that caste is no such thing at all; a youth calls him mad and walks away. Scene four: children playing during the school lunch break. "This grass-and-thatch house is mine, and I shall be a Yadav. The shop belongs to Birju, and he will be a Brahmin. We shall quarrel. Lallu, Mohan, Naren and Bablu will come and set fire to my house. Then Suresh will become the leader and Vinod the policeman. Suresh will tell the officer to get both our house and shop rebuilt and to catch those responsible. Suresh will make us shake hands and become friends." The game of Baikba-Phorba lasts the whole lunch period.

"Viṣ-Pān" ("Drinking Poison"): Gopalji sits restlessly on a chair in the lawyers' room. At the courthouse gate a parrot-owning astrologer sits beneath a banner advertising mamira collyrium to improve eyesight. From the court veranda orderly Ramesar Mandal, son of Jagesar Mandal, shouts. A litigant promises his lawyer the remaining fee at the next hearing, but the lawyer is digging his ear with the blunt end of a pen. Gopal overhears. One day at a paan shop, Chaturanan had come with a stick and beaten him until he fell. Neniya, his father's old servant, arrived and struck Chaturanan, who nevertheless escaped. The sixty-year-old mother of Ramprasad from Marauna was first to inquire after Gopal. Gopal was taken to hospital. Chaturanan, too, came there seeking treatment and an injury report; someone recognised him and chased him away with a length of drainpipe. Everyone called Chaturanan a habitual criminal, but Gopal had tried to reform him; he had now become a Bhasmasura, a destroyer of his benefactor. The police extracted money from Chaturanan and he stayed at home. Hearing dates kept being set in Gopal's case, and his X-ray plate vanished from the hospital. After three years the evidence began, followed by cross-examination: had he been wearing a full-sleeved shirt that day, had it a collar and pocket, what was its colour; how long and what sort of stick had struck him? The lawyer was his friend, but one day the sharpness of his tone was unmistakable: "You see, litigants have paid us; naturally we must attend to their work first." No testimony was recorded that day, and the judge entered an adverse observation on the file. Chaturanan settled matters for three thousand rupees, with the suggestion that Gopal might pay more if he could. An offer had also reached the lawyer-friend through counsel for the opposing party. At Gopal's request, proceedings to transfer the case began. But it was transferred to a court connected by kinship to Shilbhadra Jha, Gopalji's political rival, under whose protection Chaturanan now lived. Gopal signs a compromise petition: a surrender likened to General Niazi's surrender with a hundred thousand troops in the India–Pakistan war.

Hāthī Chalae Bazār: This short-story collection is arranged in three sections. The first, Mūldhan ("Principal"), contains stories of ordinary length, roughly two thousand words each—the form called the "short story" in English. In Maithili, however, the "short story" or laghu-kathā is often written within a single page, and a collection of those is placed in the second section, Byāj ("Interest"). The last section, Lorhā-Bicchā, contains stories of different lengths that the author evidently considers somewhat weaker. Yet after reading them, one finds that many from that last section merit inclusion under Principal and Interest, while quite a few in Principal and Interest would fit better in Lorhā-Bicchā.

Mūldhan ("Principal") — "Anhār" ("Darkness"): The road passing through Lauhar village has been paved. Government jeeps travel along it, and flocks of goats bleat on the way to be offered in sacrifice at Mahishi Ugratara. Children emerge from houses whose eaves almost touch, amid wheat and straw. Tetar Musahar used to work as a ploughman for a household in Sarauni village and was cutting straw for Ramanand Singh. The wheel of Kulwant Singh's truck ran over his boy. The village headman arrived and took six thousand rupees from Sardar Kulwant Singh, saying that two thousand would be given to Tetar. Tetar's whole body trembled: how was he to count so many five-rupee notes? Tetar tried to console his wife from Baluaha: "As long as you and I are alive, will there not be more children?"

"Tax Free": Chalittar works at a brick kiln. Instead of six and a half rupees he receives five; the overseer keeps one and a half. But a budget was passed only yesterday: an article formerly costing four rupees and seventy-five paise will now cost seven rupees and seventy paise. The candidate Chalittar had voted for has come to the inspection bungalow, so Chalittar goes to him. Before the election, he says, he could at least eat half a stomachful; now he cannot manage even that. But the leader, now a minister, rebukes him: "How many garments and cloths we distributed! We got televisions and the BDO made tax-free! Yet no one is grateful." Police throw Chalittar out, landing punches and slaps upon him. From whom is he to learn what "tax free" means?

"Babūr" ("The Acacia"): A drought-stricken man has died and must be taken on his last journey. He had only one son, Udba. The father had long felt close to the gentlemen of the village. Udba sets off towards the Brahmin quarter: even if each man contributed just one piece of wood, there would be a heap. Instead he hears taunts: "Dogs and crows ate the flesh of his forefathers, yet these drought victims now want a tree for cremation!" Udba sends word to bring the corpse to the embankment. Meanwhile he cuts and splits the acacia growing on government land and builds a pyre. He lights it. Panditji arrives and remarks that a funeral pyre should not be made of acacia; Udba should have put a torch in the dead man's mouth and floated him down the river. Furious, Udba snatches the pandit's almanac and throws it into the fire. This acacia, he says, is the sandalwood for the likes of you.

"Sambandh" ("Relationship"): Sugiya and her husband Jibachh live beside the crossroads and run a makeshift stall selling puffed rice, sweets and sugar confections. Between the evening meal and sleep they lie in one another's arms and talk. If the old woman had lived just this one more year, their

happiness might not have ended. Sugiya is pregnant. Today, while eating rice and parwar, she hears cries as her husband is being strangled by members of the extended kin group. She rushes there, but they attack her with an axe too. At the police station the sub-inspector is busy settling matters with a tractor-owner. He demands a two-hundred-rupee fee for registering her case. Jibachh has only sixty rupees in his shirt pocket. Sugiya goes to the goldsmith to sell her bangles and neck ornament, but he takes advantage of her desperation and offers too little. By the time she raises the money, Jibachh has died. The sub-inspector says he died without making any statement; perhaps Sugiya was involved with another man and had arranged for gangsters to murder her husband. He locks her in the police cell and sends word to his quarters that he will not be coming home that night.

"Antim Behośī" ("The Final Unconsciousness"): The narrator's bhauji, Lalita Mishra, is the wife of Professor Samaresh Mishra, head of the Chemistry Department. They were first teacher and pupil, then lovers, then husband and wife. There is an age gap of at least ten years. They have three children: Sushma, fourteen; Madhuri, twelve; and Shwetabh, ten. Bhauji is pregnant for the fourth time, because the hunger of the body is powerful. Her daughters are ridiculed at school and tell their mother, "Our heads split with shame at the mockery; will you never stop bearing children?" She attempts an abortion but gets no help from Samaresh Bhai. Haunted by her daughters' words and her swollen belly, she even thinks of striking it with the end of a rolling pin. She faints. Had her fourth pregnancy come fourteen years after the first child, would her daughter not have prayed to the gods, as Shipra did? Shipra, a student at the narrator's college, had welcomed a brother born when she was seventeen. The doctor's expression does not look reassuring. Bhauji's baby is now in the narrator's arms. Bhauji has left this world and its intrigues. With the twenty-six-hour-old infant, he enters Samaresh Bhai's quarters. Bhauji's ten-year-old son talks to him joyfully, without waiting for replies. Bhauji regained consciousness only long enough to leave a message: the English-medium school has turned her two daughters into Chandis; they will not let this baby live. "You are now its mother and father." The narrator is lost in thought. The sisters have gone to school. How is he to perform the funeral rites and have the ten-year-old son put on mourning garments?

"Ussar Jamin" ("Barren Land"): Tejo Babu is the narrator's kinsman, a paternal relative known to the younger people as Phul Kaka. In the days of his strength he had satisfied his lust, by consent or coercion, with women working in his fields. Now he is father-in-law to two daughters-in-law and one son-in-law. He used to imitate the narrator's squint until, through doing so, the eyeball of his own right eye seemed to disappear beneath the upper lid. Looking now at his grandchildren—their faces like the flat bowl of a roof tile, lips like old pointed gourds, potato-shaped noses, catlike eyes and cheeks like bursts of Holi powder—he repents. Arbitrators assemble to divide the property of his sons Ram and Lakshman. Ram has a daughter, and a father of daughters grows old early; Lakshman has a son. Lakshman's wife from Simraha realises that the elder brother will have to pay for one daughter's marriage next year and another soon afterwards. She looks for a pretext to

divide the family. The arbitrators, a surveyor and a labourer to weigh the grain arrive. The man who once mediated other families' quarrels now faces arbitration in his own. Everything is divided, but there is only one threshing floor and one well: the floor is broken up and the well filled in. Yet how can one break or fill in one's parents? The father goes with Ram and the mother with Lakshman. Both are left like heaps of dung and dust. The Simraha daughter-in-law sees no benefit in allotting two bighas of land from the common property to the elderly parents. When rice pudding is made in the younger son's home, a spoonful or two falls even on the old mother's leaf plate; yet eating alone wounds her heart. Phul Kaka has become a philosopher: why should a barren cow, sterile land or a lame ox expect care and maintenance?

"Pavan Pul" ("The Bridge of Air"): The narrator has taken his Intermediate Science examination, with only the practical left. He returns to the village in the interval, unwilling to place a greater burden on his low-paid father. He was in Saharsa just three days earlier. His younger sister Saroj lies on her deathbed. She is eldest among his three younger sisters, yet three years younger than he. Married at ten and sent to her husband's home at thirteen, she was brought back on a carrying pole after six months. Her husband is an ignorant good-for-nothing. The narrator used to tease him by asking when the automatic watch and the English Raleigh bicycle he demanded had been manufactured; Saroj was punished even for that teasing. In the physics practical the narrator could not measure the radius of curvature of a convex lens, but by the following morning Saroj had crossed beyond that curved boundary forever. His middle paternal uncle, whom he calls Babu, loves the narrator and Saroj more than life itself. Yet people of their own community refuse to help carry the corpse. The narrator's aunt points out the absurdity: the four women of the lineage are left to weep and console one another, while voices whisper through cracks and corners that the girl died just as she reached maturity and will become a witch galloping through the neighbourhood all night. At the funeral feast Ranganath Mishra asks who will rise first: there are only twenty-one Brahmins, one short of twenty-two. The narrator's younger uncle sits down himself. The narrator seizes Mishra by the arm and makes him stand: "Get out at once, or I shall not spare a single shoe! Let the butcher go. Give his leaf plate to the pig belonging to Bhikho Dom."

"Caritra" ("Character"): Gautamji is an ardent Communist, a Karna Kayastha by caste. He smokes bidis, useful for maintaining a proletarian image, and his moustache has curled into points. He is a Maithil settled in Calcutta, with three daughters. When arranging a daughter's marriage, he takes his lover along to inspect prospective grooms. One match is unsuitable because the family is Ambashtha Kayastha; in another the prospective groom's Karna Kayastha father has a Christian widow as his second wife. The story of Adelina enters at this point. When a headmaster remarks on Adelina, a newly appointed teacher says that Adelina would be only two or three years older than the headmaster's youngest daughter, thereby silencing him. The story ends when Gautamji's middle daughter gives her father a sharp rebuke.

"Ijot" ("Light"): The narrator is playing chess with Madhukarji. As they play

he discusses not only Madhukarji's dishonest moves on the board but also his dishonesty in life. When he calls Madhukarji the pupil of a sinful guru, Madhukarji becomes angry: "I am the one who will teach your wife to beat your parents, bring disgrace upon your house, and refuse to let your sister and brother-in-law live with you!" Their conversation over the chessboard exposes Madhukarji's peculiar talents: causing disruption at weddings, applying archery like Ekalavya to seal a dog's mouth, and tutoring the narrator's wife in absurd and disruptive behaviour. He has even told the narrator's sister's parents-in-law: "He has money to buy land in Delhi, but none to give his sister and brother-in-law?" The narrator's wife was already wielding "five brooms and five beatings" against her parents-in-law; Madhukarji has added another five blows on account of the sister. The poor woman has since died. Finally the narrator picks up Madhukarji's knight, returns it to its old square and urges him to bring honesty into his moves.

"Hāthī Chalae Bazār": Bhavani Dai was her father's beloved daughter. After her mother's death she was brought up and married. When her husband Kalyan secured a qualification, her father died on hearing the happy news—of joy, the tale says. Then Bhavani Dai bore a son, and her husband died. In seeking the insurance payment and a compassionate appointment, she encountered two kinds of official. The young manager of the insurance company was courteous and settled everything within minutes. The officer at her husband's workplace, however, was depraved. The story ends with the rebuke that his daughter Gita delivers to her father.

"Chhaguntā": Bairagiji, Ramadhin Pandey "Bairagi," has a son who has become a college professor. The tale gathers pace when that son is kidnapped. Bairagiji has withdrawn twenty-five thousand rupees from his provident fund and kept it ready, only for the money to disappear too. His elder son Arun is also missing. The narrative then turns to Dukhmochan, son of a freedom fighter who refused a pension. Dukhmochan is a criminal figure, revealing his tendencies in high school when he sexually assaulted the daughter of a neighbour disadvantaged by caste and poverty. There followed highway robbery, snatching and other crimes. Disliking the leadership of Bhagatji, an MLA from a lower caste, he implicated him in a case and became a fugitive politician, with the support of people of his own caste. His surrender and show of strength are announced for a certain date. The gathering is exclusively of his caste, "like wheat of a single colour," and includes men and women of all ages. Dukhmochan becomes a powerful man. Arun wages a righteous war against him, killing his thuggish henchmen while Dukhmochan himself enjoys life in Delhi and Patna.

"Gati" ("Course"): Jagat Jha is the village cat. The village is Mohanpur, with people of every caste except Bhumihars and Doms. Bhumihars have no place in its customary social organisation, but Doms do: hence the Dom comes from Chandrayan. After being pawned for two years with Dasai Pasi, he is again allotted to Bhikho Dom of Mohanpur. Manohar Dhanuk's daughter Chanarma also lives in the village. She knows Brahminical pretensions well. After marriage she returns from her husband's home at Bakour, leading her husband along: she did not know the demons of Bakour, whereas all the dogs

of Mohanpur knew her. She then has four daughters. Jagat Jha incites Anil Singh, son of T.T., who is coming from Tarbanni, by asking whether Chaniya has paid him what she owed. A brawl and a police case follow. Eventually both sides discover Jagat Babu's true character and join together against him.

"Madhyāntar" ("Intermission"): Jagattarini and Alka Devi are co-wives, but neither shows the slightest trace of jealousy. Alka has two children. Taranand came from a poor family and Alka from a prosperous one; they had studied together. When Taranand passed the civil-service examination, however, dowry considerations led to his marriage with Jagattarini, dark as a stone image but lovely in conduct. Through the efforts of the supposedly unattractive Jagattarini, Alka too comes into the household. Then Mira, the uneducated wife of Manohar, a distant younger male relative of Jagattarini, arrives. The bonds of Mira's marriage begin to weaken, and the lawyers enter. Mira wins her case, but Manohar's lawyer and Mira's own lawyer exploit her sexually. Jagattarini then offers Mira reassurance and trust.

Byāj ("Interest") — "Kirāyā" ("Rent"): Gulabbagh in Purnia is a centre of commercial sex. Amid cries that some lepers have been rubbed and made to swell and that for ten rupees one may obtain "your own companion and your father's companion," a voice addresses the narrator: "The bastard has neither strength in his pocket nor in his loins."

"Patan" ("Fall"): In floodwater, Chanma tries to recover the contents of Jholi Misar's trunk. A snake raises its hood as if saying, "I am not more venomous than you."

"Usās" ("Breath"): A widowed woman from Thana has a sick daughter, Doli. She stops going to the mansion to work, and the master twists ten rupees out of her. Her mother tells Doli the tale of the Rohu fish who suffered oppression and was killed when a kabai fish lodged a thorn in its throat. Doli asks, "Is there no kabai fish for this master?"

"Otghan": A servant, Musba, is refused leave for the Jitiya festival. The mistress applies Jitbahan's ritual oil generously to her own child's head, while Musba hopes for a single drop. In a dream his mother asks why he has come away: "There, your mistress would have served the otghan meal with curd made from pure milk." He answers that the offering oil never even escaped the hand of that Simbakshi woman; what otghan meal could she have served him?

"Jāgriti" ("Awakening"): A crow perches at the fork of a royal road, before the Parliament House shining as though bathed in milk, like a young woman emerging from a milk bath. The familiar tale is repeated: a dog asks a crow to sing so that it can eat the bread. But the crow holds the bread in its claw and answers, "Living in a hollow, how will you hear the songs of the outside world?"

"Jāti" ("Caste"): Kameshwar Babu has a sexual relationship with Sugni, who works in his house. Many years later he looks lustfully at Sugni's daughter Sarasatiya and asks about her. Sugni replies that the girl is indeed grown, but she is wondering what caste of boy to seek for her marriage: one of her own caste, or one of Kameshwar Babu's.

"Mahāmantrī" ("General Secretary"): Vinod, with an MA in economics, becomes trapped in the manoeuvres of Agriculture Minister Pandeyji. His

paddy-husking business suffers, and the funds allotted by Pandeyji are siphoned away above his head.

"Ekodiṣṭa" ("The Funeral Offering"): The father, known as Malik Baba, has died. His eldest son Madhu Bhai, in anger also called Madhukanta, is enraged when the invited man fails to attend and cares nothing for the guest's official obligations. He asks why Sunara was not invited instead. Madhu Bhai hurries in and overhears the remark.

"Bhārat" ("India"): Gandhi's statue falls. Passers-by respectfully bow before it but none takes the trouble to lift it. A beggar continues begging beside the fallen statue despite receiving fewer alms, hoping that when Gandhi Baba rises he can tell him of the country's condition.

"Kṛtajñatā" ("Gratitude"): Susmit, Akshayvat and Rakesh are walking and talking. Thanks to Professor Ramnarayan Singh, someone had received good examination marks. The professor meets the narrator, and the secret emerges that the marks were given in return for the present of a fine umbrella.

"Visangati" ("Incongruity"): The narrator is a medical representative. Natho Bahin needs medicine for stomach pain, Tejo Kaka for a case of ringworm, and Awadhesh Bhai pills to stimulate his appetite. But Subelal, the ploughman, whose son is five years older than the narrator, calls him "master." He does not want medicine for a bad stomach: he cannot obtain as much food as his stomach could digest. He asks whether there is a medicine that would reduce hunger.

"Boin" ("Wages"): Jugo Marar's wife Dhoraywali crosses the threshing ground at Kinkar Babu's home without wages; her son Lalmohra works there too merely for food. With the narrator's help she is granted an old-age pension. Yet her employer will not pay wages for the two days he sends her away from work. At the block office an official accepts her papers without taking money. She concludes that her business must not have been done: how could any poor person's work be accomplished without wages or payment?

"Pahicān" ("Recognition"): During a funeral rite involving the dedication of a tree, a calf dies from being struck by the wooden implement.

"Anuttarit" ("Unanswered"): Dina Babu's sexual appetite is met with a question from Budhni, his ploughman's daughter: "In this salwar frock, do I look like his eldest sister?"

"Yogyatā" ("Qualification"): Rafiq Sahib opens a school and, in judging a young woman's qualifications, asks her age. The story is not powerful.

"Uddeśya" ("Purpose"): The chief minister demands the education minister's resignation in connection with the proposed prohibition of cheating in examinations.

"Bodh" ("Understanding"): A king sees the serpent king's wife having intercourse with a water-creature and hears her question: "Is a grain of virility not greater than a mountain of noble lineage?"

"Mol-Jol" ("Bargaining"): On Panki Road in Daltonganj, during the death rites for Bharat Babu's mother, a Brahmin receiving milk and oil demands a hundred and fifty-one rupees, then another fifty, and is still dissatisfied. A Brahmin beggar offers to drink the milk and sesame mixture for that sum instead.

"Mūlya" ("Value"): Manorama studies for her PhD under Lakhan Babu. When he proposes a love affair, she replies, "With the very eyes that have seen you as so great a figure, how can I see you naked?"
"Āsthā" ("Faith"): During an emergency, Panditji proposes to perform the cow-gift rite with eleven rupees, sesame, kuśa grass, barley and unbroken rice instead of an actual cow. When the narrator questions this substitute, the priest says, "Is it a human being? It is an animal—an animal!"
"Antim Abhilāṣ" ("Last Wish"): Asked for his dying wish, Madar Das says he longs to eat potato curry and rice.
"Sarokār" ("Concern"): Phul Babu dies. Just then dollars arrive for a poem published in America, prompting Madaneshwar Babu to ask how much it will amount to in Indian currency.
"Pratibaddhatā" ("Commitment"): Ramsharanji's understanding of Indian poverty and the exploitation of women is so lucid from reading foreign authors. Lalita has been engrossed in his work for a month. But when a discussion of feminism exposes the difference between his professed theory and conduct, and Lalita rebukes him, he declares feminism a weapon wielded by impertinent young women to subdue men.
"Jogār" ("Arrangements"): After Kumar Gandharva's death, two newspaper reviewers in JNU's Kaveri Hostel dispute who should write about him. One claims to have been writing articles on Gandharva since the day the musician first became ill; he tells the other to write a poem instead.
"Piṇḍadān": Chakradhar Babu refuses to pay Jhingur Jha for land taken after Jha's mother's death. On the night before Chakradhar sets off for Gaya to offer piṇḍa to his ancestors, he dreams: do not dispossess the living; the dead will settle themselves.

Lorhā-Bicchā — "Bhūkh" ("Hunger"): Ramkisna was the narrator's childhood companion. Now Ramkisna grazes cattle while the narrator is a professor. On Holi, when the narrator attempts to put colour on him, Ramkisna says colour cannot cling to filthy, soiled clothes. His stomach has been burning for four days.
"Mahagī Unmūlan" ("Eradication of High Prices"): Manindra walks along a Patiala road with his father and family. Everyone except speakers of one language is being hacked down like radishes and turnips. He survives, and later comes at Holi to play with His Excellency, using foul-smelling water rather than the colours of the corpses, because the water is cheaper.
"Kasāī" ("Butcher"): Surenma's land lies in the way of making Bilat Singh's field rectangular, but Surenma will not consent. He is beaten. The sub-inspector demands money; even an appeal to the superintendent of police achieves nothing, because the sub-inspector secured his position by paying a bribe to that very officer.
"Dahej" ("Dowry"): The narrator's younger sister refuses to return to her husband's house for the gauna unless she takes along a matchstick and a tin of kerosene.
"Pīṛhīk Dvandva" ("Conflict of Generations"): The wheel of fate, differences between Saheb Rai and Ramdev Rai, and the change of a father's name from Ramdev to Chaturbhuj Rai.

"Pahine, Āi, ā Kālhi" ("Yesterday, Today and Tomorrow"): The narrator asks Gonu Baba a question; Gonu replies that people will weep in the past, present and future over the stick, rice and revolver ball.
"Pratiphal" ("Consequence"): The consequences of Bharati and Sharad's scientific theory. Methods for determining the birth of a son have reduced the number of girls; now men wage wars over women.
"Uparāg" ("Eclipse"): Kamo Jha's first wife came from Dibra, his second from Murli. The second wife had a son and three daughters. A snake bites her son Niranjan—is it because he worshipped by touching the Shiva liṅga, or because of the first wife's supposed witchcraft? Kamo's father Musai Jha had an illicit relationship with his daughter-in-law from Dibra. At the death of the wife from Murli, people ask her son Indradev to light the funeral pyre. She discloses a secret: "You are not his son; you are his … his younger brother!"
"Kou Kāhū Magan" ("Each Content in His Own Way"): The narrator and companions are out walking when Chaudharyji finds a ten-rupee note on the road. Whose money can it be? If a hollow appears in one place, must some other place not rise higher?
"Ṛṇkhauk" ("Debtor"): Nilesh comes from a poor family. After he gains an education, village people pressure his father into arranging his marriage. His wife is such that she beats his father. Nilesh decides to marry a woman of another caste; a neighbour says, "He is a debtor: he will die before he has repaid the debt to his father."

Story: Among the educated middle class, those who study Maithili from Class IX through the undergraduate and postgraduate levels, whether as a language or their mother tongue, develop affection for it. The arrival of Maithili on the internet has rekindled affection for the mother tongue. Maithili books, including textbooks produced by government institutions, have remained difficult to obtain; the internet has intervened in this situation, but only to a limited extent. Consequently a sense of inferiority has entered Maithili writers (a superiority complex is itself a form of inferiority), and literature has begun to stand on a raised mound of self-regard. Controversies are manufactured, with literary debate reduced to charges and countercharges. Husbands and wives, districts and regions, fathers and sons have begun creating favourable environments for themselves: stories and poems are written for prizes through blackmail and black marketing. Yet even literary works awarded the Booker or the Nobel Prize do not necessarily endure forever. Many are remembered, many are forgotten, and readers eventually determine their value. In Maithili, however, generations pass and, in the absence of readers, spouses, fathers and sons, regional factions and now circles of poets and fiction writers determine merit by blackmail. Because the internet's intervention is still limited, fine literature, creative literature and writing beneficial to society do not come forward or are not produced. Will you encourage poets and fiction writers who stay in the news by provoking disputes because they are practising blackmail—or humanistic poets and fiction writers who remain among the dust and earth? Only when you make that choice will you be able to infuse life into what appears to be a purposeless Maithili literature.

92. The Present Problems of the Maithils

Abstract

Proletarian Maithil culture is passing through a revolutionary upheaval. Migration can be a good thing, but in a culture where whole villages have become empty within a single generation, migration has appeared as a curse. Twenty per cent of the Maithil cultural region lies in Nepal and eighty per cent in India.

Keywords: Maithils · Present · Problems · Literary Criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Synopsis

This chapter examines the present problems of the Maithils from a linguistic and cultural perspective. Its main points of reference include Maithils, their problems, embankments and Maithili. Through the examples and arguments supplied in the source, it considers language structure, vocabulary, translation and writing practices, so that readers can appreciate the critical framework of the chapter and its wider context.

Proletarian Maithil culture is passing through a period of revolutionary upheaval. Migration may be a good thing, yet in a culture where entire villages have become deserted in a single generation, it has taken the form of a curse. Twenty per cent of the region of Maithil culture lies in Nepal, and eighty per cent in India. Migration has thus produced economic, social, political and cultural crises in the region.

Causes: The famine of 1967 and the administrative lethargy that persisted for several years thereafter, followed by the flood of 1987 and several more years of administrative inertia, combined to bring about an economic crisis. Migration consequently assumed its most severe form and produced a cultural crisis. When economic conditions deteriorate, caste rigidity also grows. Mithila's culture contains many factors that assist and many that obstruct a way out of this crisis. The gentle rises and falls of the local language, the wide-ranging abilities of the region's working people, and also the rigidity of its habits and cultural practices are all parts of Mithila's history. These encompass politics, everyday life, social values, economic circumstances, morality, religion, philosophy and literature. The region produced a Vidyapati, who embraced different groups of society, yet it also sustained deeply conservative elements.

Education, Caste and the Condition of Women: There is stratification within a single caste and conflict between castes, along with polygamy, child marriage and the bikauā form of marriage in which a bridegroom is effectively purchased. There has not even been a symbolic movement against child marriage or in support of widow remarriage. The Śūdra poet Ailūṣa composed Vedic hymns; the society in that earlier period was so vigorous that Alexander encountered fierce resistance from the republican groups referred to as the Śūdras. Similarly, in Mithila, when artisans and all those relegated to the so-called lower strata of society were strong, the name of Janaka was derived from the people (jan), and a remarkable sequence of fortifications

emerged as expressions of Mithila's architecture: Simraungarh, Pajebagarh, Balirajpur Fort, Asurgarh Fort, Jainagar Fort, Nandangarh, Katragarh, Naulagarh, Mangalgarh, Kichakgarh, Benugarh and Barijangarh, among others. Those forts accorded with the name of Mithila, understood here as a land that subdued its enemies. Buddhist caves, images of Tārā and other works of craftsmanship also represent different forms of artistic activity. As rigidity increased, however, Mithila's achievement in architecture dwindled until today it appears to have reached zero. Economic circumstances deteriorated to the point that families went without an evening meal. Migration prevented starvation, but at a price. In much the same way, learned women such as Maitreyī disappeared for a millennium because of caste rigidity—both internal stratification within castes and separation between castes. The decline of education was so severe that although four of the six philosophical schools originated in Mithila, according to the author's account, whole villages today are filled with people who have not passed the matriculation examination.

Floods and the Economy: The land of Mithila has also had to struggle with the devastation caused by floods. The area around Kusheshwarsthan remains submerged during the rains even when there is no actual flood. This, however, is a condition that developed after 1978–79. Earlier the area was entirely fertile, but uncontrolled construction of embankments in India caused water to become trapped there. News of flooding in the area scarcely ever appears; when it does, it is often accompanied by propaganda claiming that all the accumulated water was released by Nepal. The people around Kusheshwarsthan have learned the art of fighting this new calamity. I remember being told to travel from Kusheshwarsthan to Mahishi Ugratarasthan in the rainy season because, at that time, going by boat was easier. In the dry season boats cannot move through the pits and shallow pools, while the condition of the roads is better left undescribed. People altered their crops and tried fish farming by whatever means they could, learning, under compulsion, an entirely new way of life. Then came the fury of the Kausiki Maharani—the Kosi—in 2008. The two barrages on the Kosi and Gandak in Nepal are, the text argues, controlled by the Water Resources Department of the Bihar government, under the supervision of Bihar's engineers. The decision to release water is in that department's hands. Nepal would have the authority to release water only when other barrages or embankments were constructed on its rivers; even after more than fifty years, this has not proved possible because the two countries have been unable to reach an agreement. The Bhimnagar barrage on the Kosi is at Kusaha in Nepal. The embankment constructed in 1958 had an anticipated life of thirty years, expiring in 1988. Why could the countries not arrive at a settlement? Sand that accumulates between the embankments is removed every year; otherwise, the level of the riverbed rises and the embankments must be raised again and again. The Kosi abandons its principal channel, takes a new course, and devastates both the Mithila region of Nepal and the Mithila region of Bihar.

Maithili Language: Organisations that claim to serve Maithili, traditionally organised around Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas and occupied with Vidyapati festivals, institutional creation and the distribution of awards, have

allowed only restricted entry to those outside those two groups. Their participation is now increasing, however, and that is a good sign for Maithili. The number of authors and readers from other communities is also growing. In the modern information society, interventions by the media and the educational system have seemed almost an assault on Maithili language and culture. Fortunately, television channels such as Mithila and radio stations in Nepal such as Kantipur FM, Janaki FM and Radio Mithila have checked this assault to a limited extent. Children's literature has also grown, and the internet has begun to intervene in Maithili literature, albeit somewhat one-sidedly.

What Should Be Done? Education for women, computer education and vocational instruction should be provided according to local conditions. Primary instruction throughout Mithila should be conducted in Maithili. The flood problem must be solved. Why have projects comparable to the Damodar Valley or Mayurakshi projects not proved possible on the Kosi, Kamala, Bhutahi Balan, Gandak, Burhi Gandak and Bagmati? Why did Visvesvaraya's Vrindavan dam succeed? For how long will we deceive the people by placing all the blame on the government of Nepal? The text proposes, as its fundamental remedy, dismantling and removing the earthen embankments erected along the Kamala-Balan and other rivers with heavy machinery, and building lined, permanent canals rather than unlined channels. There must be negotiations with Nepal and an early solution. Until then, short-term measures must be taken: remove sand accumulated between embankments before the rains arrive; repair the embankments in advance rather than waiting for the monsoon; and keep political ambition out of the work. In 1960 embankments were built on the Kamala from Jainagar to Jhanjharpur, inaugurating, in the author's assessment, the devastation of the entire region. I have already described in the account of Kusheshwar what happened to the area beyond Jhanjharpur. The stories of Madhepur, Ghanshyampur and Singhia are no different. As sand progressively filled the space between the two Kamala-Balan embankments, everything was devastated within twenty years of their construction. The state of the Kamala is such that its water level can rise more than two metres in ten hours. By 1965 so much sand had already collected between the embankments that calls arose either to raise them further or to demolish them. Here one remembers Visvesvaraya. Dams were constructed on the Musi and Esi rivers, eighty-two miles from Hyderabad, and a subsidiary channel of the Musi was developed six and a half miles from the city. Embankments were also raised on both sides of the river within the city. When the Mysore state submitted Visvesvaraya's scheme for the Krishnaraja Sagar dam, with its proposed height of 130 feet, to the British, Viceroy Hardinge reduced it to eighty feet. Visvesvaraya compensated by widening the lower portion. When flooding intervened in the middle of construction, he hired additional workers and doctors to treat labourers suffering from malaria and other illnesses, installed Washington lamps for night work, and made up for lost time through personal supervision. His patriotism, the passage argues, was such that he did not import cement, but used surkhi prepared from sand,

calcium, stone and powdered fired bricks to construct the dam. A two-level canal system had already been built before work began on the dam itself.

Delhi Is Still Far Away! Pressure must be brought to bear on the central government in Delhi on the following points. What harm would there be in giving schools and colleges a holiday during floods rather than in the summer heat? Why is this decision so difficult? Leave aside CBSE and ICSE: even the Bihar Board has failed to do it. According to local conditions, women should receive education, training in computers and vocational education, while primary schooling throughout Mithila should be delivered in Maithili. While the barrage is being constructed, permanent lined canals should be laid according to the natural slope of the land. Earthen embankments should be demolished and removed, and permanent embankments made suitable for motor traffic, with adequate trees planted on either side. Just as the Bihar road projects appear to be turning a dream into reality, all obstacles should be removed and this work begun on a war footing.

93. From the Videha Editorials

Abstract

When I speak Maithili on my mobile phone, my colleague Gauri Bhola says, "It is a very sweet language." Gayatri Shyankat says, "Your language is Maithili, and we have named our daughter Maithili." I cannot make them understand the bitterness beneath that sweetness. For various reasons, 2012 will be remembered in the history of the Maithili language and its literature.

Keywords: Videha · Editorials · Literary Criticism · Maithili

Abstract · Summary

This chapter presents theatrical criticism on the subject "From the Videha Editorials." Videha, editorials, Maithili, Shri, and literature emerge as its principal centres of attention. Using the examples, quotations, and arguments available in the original material, the discussion examines dramatic texts, character arrangement, stage structure, and cultural contexts, enabling readers to understand both the critical structure of the subject and its wider context.

When I speak Maithili on my mobile phone, my colleague Gauri Bhola says, "It is a very sweet language." Gayatri Shyankat says, "Your language is Maithili, and we have named our daughter Maithili."

I cannot make them understand the bitterness beneath that sweetness.

For various reasons, 2012 will be remembered in the history of Maithili language and literature. At the beginning of that year, the "First Videha Maithili Theatre Festival" was held at Chanauraganj (Jhanjharpur), under the leadership of Bechan Thakur, to establish a parallel Maithili theatre in opposition to caste-based theatre. Bechan Thakur had directed Maithili plays for the preceding twenty-five to thirty years. He had written about a dozen plays, repeatedly staged to critical acclaim. The festival's theme was "Maithili Drama and Theatre in the Perspective of India's Nāṭyaśāstra." During this two-day, day-and-night festival, Jagdish Prasad Mandal's play *Vīrāṅganā*, Bechan Thakur's *Viśvāsghāt*, and Gajendra Thakur's *Utkāmukh* were performed. One-act plays based on women's empowerment and folk ballads were also staged. A Maithili poetry gathering took place, and Videha honours were presented.

The Videha Language Honour, known as the Parallel Sahitya Akademi Award, emerged as a response to what I regard as the forty-five-year grip of ostensibly literary, caste-specific institutions over the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili department. In forty-four years, the award had gone thirty-six times to Maithil Brahmins, six times to Kayasthas, twice to Rajputs, and not once to a writer from a non-upper-caste background. Worthy Brahmin writers such as Lalit, Dhumketu, and Dhirendra were denied the distinction, while Harimohan Jha never received it during his lifetime. The list, in my judgment, is crowded with reactionary writers. Subhash Chandra Yadav,

Meghnath Prasad, Bindeshwar Mandal, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Nichiketa, and other non-Brahmin writers, held in the highest regard within Maithili literature, have suffered under what I consider the Brahminical disposition of the Sahitya Akademi.

There was opposition to the invitation extended to Jagdish Prasad Mandal as chief guest at the Vikhyāti Parva in Guwahati, organised by activists of the Mithila-state movement in December 2012. That opposition was strongly condemned.

Vidyāpati. Vidyāpati is a great poet of Maithili. According to tradition, he belonged to a Thakur family of barbers. Jyotirishwar Thakur described him in the *Varṇa Ratnākara*, while Shridhar Das referred to his *Padāvalī*, with examples, in the *Sadukti-karṇāmṛta*. The Maithil Brahmin genealogical registers mention a later author named Vidyāpati, who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa and lived after Shridhar Das and Jyotirishwar. Yet certain Brahminical institutions have tried to turn the pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyāpati into a Brahmin by putting a *pāg* on his head and symbolically performing his sacred-thread ceremony. This is regarded here as a conspiracy to perform a corresponding initiation upon the Maithili language itself. Literary circles debated the issue throughout the year; it was also raised at the India Habitat Centre's Indian Languages Festival at year's end. Through Vidyāpati festivals, a conservative section of Maithil Brahmins, in collaboration with caste-based theatre, continued trying to establish control over Maithili. Ordinary people, therefore, were distancing themselves from these activities.

Tagore Literature Award. The first Tagore Literature Award for Maithili was given to Jagdish Prasad Mandal for his collection of short-short stories, *Gāmak Jingī*. Yet no Hindi newspaper in the Mithila region, including Darbhanga, reported it; All India Radio, Darbhanga, likewise maintained complete silence. In my view, that silence exposed these institutions' caste bias before the public.

Google Videha Books. With Google's cooperation, Videha made more than four hundred Maithili books available online through Google Books, with full browsing and downloading facilities. An English–Maithili dictionary was released under a Creative Commons ShareAlike licence.

The appointment of the Maithili coordinator at the Sahitya Akademi and the politics of the Akademi awards. The Sahitya Akademi has recognised six organisations, which I describe as casteist, for the selection of its Maithili coordinator. These organisations appointed Maithili's eighth coordinator. Whether by coincidence or misfortune, every coordinator to date has been a Maithil Brahmin; the pattern continued this time. In presenting the Youth Award, the rules were, in my view, swept aside: books nominated by the referees were not even considered, while an ordinary book by an author who writes principally in Hindi received the award.

Is Maithili only the language of Maithil Brahmins? If the Sahitya Akademi and caste-based organisations had their way, the answer would be yes. The parallel intellectual movement and parallel theatre, however, have challenged that assumption. At https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-pothi/ one can find online Videha's Maithili short fiction, microfiction, poetry, theatre festival, children's festival, and collections of treatises, essays, and criticism. The response the Sahitya Akademi gave to Vineet Utpal's Right to Information application should shame the literary world. In my assessment, the manner in which the coordinator and advisory-board members allotted assignments to themselves and their relatives exposes the Brahminical tendencies of these institutions.

Rajdev Mandal, Ramvilas Sahu, Umesh Paswan, Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jhādūdār," Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Umesh Mandal, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Premshankar Singh, Dr Uday Narayan Singh "Nichiketa," Meghnath Prasad, Sandeep Kumar Safi, Bindeshwar Thakur, and many others are selflessly providing Maithili with the breath of life.

The politics of the pāg. What I call the Brahminical politics of the *pāg* suffered a major setback when the organisers of the Mahakavi Laldas Jayanti at Kharao, for the first time, acknowledged that this caste-specific headgear should not be used on a platform representing Mithila and Maithili, and acted accordingly. This was seen as an important victory for the parallel movement.

Maithili as the medium of education in primary and middle schools. Even after a Supreme Court decision, Maithili has still not become the medium of instruction in Mithila. A meeting on this subject was held at Nimli. Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Ramvilas Sahu, Rajdev Mandal, and Virendra Yadav attended a Videha discussion meeting convened by Rahul Kumar, and a signature campaign was undertaken. Concern was also voiced that the casteist and reactionary syllabus of Maithili literature needed to be changed: under what servile mentality had the biographies of oppressive, casteist landlords been inserted in it? A memorandum was handed to Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on the occasion of the inauguration of the Kosi bridge.

Videha meetings were also held on various dimensions of literature, combining discussion with practical laboratory demonstrations.

Maithili in Nepal. With the support of the Danish embassy, Ramesh Ranjan's play *Budhiyār Chhauṛā ā Rākṣas* (The Clever Boy and the Demon) was staged at around a dozen locations. The Vidyāpati Award was announced, and Rambharos Kapari "Bhramar" received the award of two lakh rupees.

At a theatre event in Janakpur, Maithili plays and cultural programmes were presented; the cultural programme included song and dance.

On Janaki Navami, a bomb exploded in Janakpur. Several cultural workers, including Jhagru Mandal, were killed, and Parmeshwar Kapari was injured.

Health. Under the principal slogan "Healthy Women, Healthy Families—Healthy Society," street plays were presented at Yadukoha and Machhi Jhitkaiya. With the support of PCI Nepal, Chitrit Rangmanch of Janakpur staged the Maithili street play *Jangalme Mangal*, based on family planning.

The Yuva Natya Kala Parishad of Parwaha Deuri organised an international Maithili theatre festival in the first session of Vimali Sharad 2069. It was inaugurated by Dr Ram Baran Yadav, the first President of republican Nepal. Eight theatre groups from Nepal and India participated.

Nichiketa's *Ek Chhal Rājā* (Once There Was a King) was staged at Tilathi during the Saraswati Puja celebration and Basant Panchami Fair of 2068.

When I was a child, we saw both the "native crow" and the "black crow" in our village. The black crow was glossy and harsh-voiced, while the native crow was lighter in colour and sang in a sweeter voice. On hearing a person speak roughly, people would say, "Why are you cawing like a black crow?" For some time now the native crow has disappeared, and people mourn its loss. The black crow's dominion has become notorious.

Tomas Tranströmer. It was announced that the Swedish poet Tomas Tranströmer would receive the 2011 Nobel Prize in Literature, worth 1.5 million dollars. The Swedish Academy said that through his intensely translucent images he had introduced us to a new opening upon truth. English translations of his books included *The Great Enigma*, *The Half-Finished Heaven*, and *The Deleted World*. He was eighty, had written more than fifteen poetry collections, and his work had been translated into English and sixty other languages. Born in Stockholm, he worked as a psychologist, and his poetry displays profound psychological understanding of humanity. His poems are enigmatic yet direct, at once personal and public. Their mystery is not something that leaves the reader in perpetual anxiety; rather, it lifts one from the ground to the highest reaches of existence. The canals of Sweden in winter, the rhythm of the seasons, and the beauty of the natural environment are marvellously evoked in them. His mother was a schoolteacher and his father a journalist; he studied literature, history, theology, and psychology. Following a stroke in 1990, he had been unable to speak. The account adds that no American writer had received the Nobel Prize in Literature after 1993 and that this was the first Swedish recipient since 1974. It anticipates greater consideration of literature in non-European languages by the Nobel Committee.

Videha Literature Festival 2012. The Videha Literature Festival and the Videha Literary Honours ceremony were held on 14 January 2012. The Parallel Sahitya Akademi Awards were presented and a poetry gathering was organised. The voluntary support and participation of the public will be remembered as evidence of the success of the Videha Maithili literary movement.

Maithili Muslims and non-upper-caste people—and now even members of upper castes—moved away from official Maithili and turned to Urdu and

Hindi. The author observes that, apart from Tamil, Malayalam, Bengali, and Kashmiri, analogous shifts have occurred in other language communities. In Kashmir people speak Kashmiri but are taught through Urdu, just as Hindi is the language of instruction in Bihar. Yet in the small state of Sikkim, despite the predominance of Nepali, Lepcha and Bhutia are also taught; those smaller languages are not endangered by this practice, the Lepcha script is protected, and Nepali itself is strengthened. The explanation, in this account, is Sikkim's linguistic generosity, which has been absent in Bihar in its treatment of Maithili and Mithila from the age of landlord rule to the present. In Darjeeling, although Nepali predominates as Hindi does in Bihar, the corresponding generosity is said to be lacking within West Bengal.

Videha Parallel Sahitya Akademi Maithili Poetry Conference, 2011. The first parallel Sahitya Akademi Maithili poetry conference organised by Videha took place at Nimli, Supaul district, on 9 July 2011, from 4:45 p.m. until 7:45 p.m. The Kolkata Maithili poetry conference organised by the Sahitya Akademi had not invited Rajdev Mandal, author of *Ambarā*, regarded here as the finest Maithili poetry collection of the first decade of the twenty-first century, or other leading poets; they had not even been informed. To remedy this exclusion, Videha organised its conference on the same day on the premises of Asafal Das Sahu Samaj Mahila Inter College, Nimli, Ward 7, Supaul district. No one was barred. Harinarayan Kamat and Ramji Mandal inaugurated the proceedings by lighting lamps. At the conclusion, Rajdev Mandal's collection *Ambarā*, published in 2010, was formally released by the assembled dignitaries: Dr Bachendra Jha, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Ramji Prasad Mandal, Roshan Kumar Gupta, Harinarayan Kamat, and Nand Vilas Rai. Poetry was read by (1) Radhakant Mandal, a welcome song; (2) Umesh Paswan, "Gelhe Ghar Chhi," "Hāl," and "Kabāṛī"; (3) Ramkrishna Mandal "Chhotu," "Māi"; (4) Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jhādūdār," five songs; (5) Nand Vilas Rai, "Indira Āvās"; (6) Kapileshwar Sahu, "Kosi"; (7) Ramvilas Sahu, three poems; (8) Umesh Mandal, two poems; (9) Rajdev Mandal, three poems; and (10) Jagdish Prasad Mandal, two poems. Each reading was followed by a brief critical response. Dr Bachendra Jha chaired the poetry conference, and Dugdhanand Mandal conducted the proceedings.

According to members of the audience, the distinguishing feature of the conference was that such an event had never before been held in their area. Jagdish Prasad Mandal, the chief guest, said during the proceedings that the event had been organised in such haste because the Sahitya Akademi was holding a Maithili poetry conference in Kolkata that day. It was shameful, he said, that an event which ought to be held in our own villages was being conducted in Kolkata, without the villagers even knowing about it.

People also said that until then programmes in the area had been conducted in Hindi; this was the first time an event had been conducted there in Maithili.

Rajesh Ranjan and Sangeeta Kumari's Maithili Fedora Project/FUEL Project: http://maithili.sourceforge.net/; http://ansiss.org/; http://fedoraproject.org/;

https://fedorahosted.org/fuel/wiki/fuel-maithili;
http://l10n.gnome.org/teams/mai;
http://translate.fedoraproject.org/languages/mai

Rajesh Ranjan and Sangeeta Kumari's Maithili spell-checker:
http://extensions.services.openoffice.org/project/dict-mai

A voluntary group led by Rajesh Ranjan of Madhepura and Sangeeta Kumari prepared this well-known browser for use in Maithili, alongside efforts towards a complete computer environment in the language.

http://www.mozilla.org/en-US/firefox/all.html

The latest Maithili version of Firefox has now been released—a success achieved through the efforts of Sangeeta Kumari and the Maithili team. Firefox–Mozilla has its own network of resources...

Videha discussions were held at Nimli, Supaul district, on 6–7 and 13–14 December 2008; 5–6 and 12–13 December 2009; 4–5 and 11–12 December 2010; and finally on 17–18 and 24–25 December 2011. They addressed the Google Translator Toolkit for Maithili, Google Language Tools, approval of applications to encode both the Kaithi and Mithilakshar scripts in the Universal Character Set (Unicode), and Maithili Wikipedia. These meetings included practical laboratory demonstrations, with many specialists in attendance. Afterwards, articles and creative submissions also arrived by post and email. A brief account follows.

Google Translator Toolkit now lists Maithili both as a source language and as a target language. See
http://support.google.com/translate/toolkit/bin/answer.py?hl=en&answer=147837 and http://translate.google.com/toolkit/list?hl=en#translations/active.

Following Videha's protest, Google has, according to the editorial, acknowledged that there is no distinct language called "Bihari." Videha had already submitted an application for "Maithili Wikipedia," and Wikipedia had earlier accepted the contention that "Bihari" is not the name of a language.

Google Maithili: Google Language Tool—http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseProject

There, select "Bihari" in the English-language interface and contribute translations for Google Translate. When revising a submitted translation, enter an explanation in English that "Bihari" is not the name of a language. Translate at this link after signing into your Google account.

http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseActivity?project=gws&langcode=bh

Keep checking this link for the availability of Maithili: http://www.google.co.in/language_tools?hl=en.

Another Videha success: Google's search engine is now available in Maithili. Previously Google classified it as "Bihari," but, following Videha's objection, it agreed, the editorial says, to provide a separate search interface for Maithili. Wikipedia had earlier accepted the same argument after Videha's protest.

The link is https://www.google.com/webhp?hl=bh.

[Google first introduced a search engine under the name "Bihari," although no language bears that name. Someone translated "Bihari" into Angika—as someone else had used the code *bh* for Bhojpuri rather than "Bihari" in Wikipedia—and the Google search engine appeared under the name "Angika." Vineet Utpal of Videha then wrote to Google; Videha undertook all the translation work voluntarily and appealed for help from the public, but received no contributions from outside. The occasional contribution that did arrive was in Roman script and was corrected. The search engine is now displayed as Maithili, although considerable work remains. The code *bh* persists in Wikipedia and Google, and efforts to remove it continue. For the discussion at the Videha meeting, see http://esamaad.blogspot.in/2012/01/blog-post_08.html.]

When translation is completed, Maithili will appear here: http://www.google.com/language_tools?hl=bh; http://www.google.com/language_tools.

VINIT UTPAL'S LETTER—http://groups.google.com/group/google-translate-general/browse_thread/thread/65656d86716ddf18/a9bdfbc9eac5a7a1?lnk=gst&q=maithili#a9bdfbc9eac5a7a1

Notice 1. Anshuman Pandey's applications to encode both the Kaithi and Mithilakshar scripts in the Universal Character Set (Unicode) have been accepted. The process of producing Unicode fonts for both scripts is under way; once their turn comes, work on their basic fonts will begin. The basic Mithilakshar font will be called Tirhuta, just as the basic Devanagari font is Mangal and the basic Bengali font is Vrinda. An application concerning Mithilakshar was submitted for the third time in revised form. The second and third applications discussed Videha's contribution at length, including the following acknowledgement: "[Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22; Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http://www.videha.co.in/. 'Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and corresponded at length about Maithili, offered valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and provided feedback regarding requirements for the encoding of Maithili in the UCS.'—Anshuman Pandey.]"

Distribution of a leaflet on Unicode at the Sahitya Akademi's Delhi fiction gathering. Dr Ramanand Jha "Raman" distributed a leaflet concerning Unicode at the Sahitya Akademi's fiction meeting. To me it only demonstrated that its author had neither a sound understanding of Unicode nor even elementary knowledge of how Webtan or Unicode fonts are made. It did, however, provide a lesson to those who wish to learn how prejudiced and partisan histories of Maithili literature are written. Consider, too, the claim made in a Chetna Samiti souvenir concerning that organisation's contribution to Unicode. When Anshuman Pandey, who had applied for the encoding of Tirhuta, visited Patna, I told him that Shiv Kumar Thakur had a bookshop in Vidyapati Bhavan where he could buy Maithili books. But on two or three successive days the shop and the committee office were closed, and he had to return. Someone there subsequently told him, "You keep coming every day, but the committee will remain closed for at least another fourteen or fifteen days, because there has been a quarrel between two groups." He went away with that experience—yet the committee describes in its souvenir the contribution it supposedly made to Unicode! When he asked for Govind Jha's address, another "scholar" exclaimed that Govind Jha would have nothing to tell him, and refused to give it. The address was eventually obtained elsewhere.

Notice 2. Maithili Wikipedia. Members of Videha have translated 2,600 MediaWiki messages from English into Maithili. Go to http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special:Translate?task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai; in the "Group" dropdown, choose untranslated messages and translate them. If you are not yet a Wikipedia translator, request permission to translate into Maithili at http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project:Translator. First log in at the upper right (or create an account if you have none); select Maithili as your language in Preferences and save your account preferences. You should receive permission to translate after a little while. You can then begin translating.

Notice 3. TWITTER IN MAITHILI. Open http://translate.twttr.com/welcome and scroll down to the message "[Don't see your language? We're continually reviewing the list of languages we support, and would love your feedback]." Follow the feedback link, submit as many requests for Maithili as possible, and give your reasons in the space provided.

Videha Language Honour 2012–13 (presented as an alternative to the Sahitya Akademi Award). The Videha Honour for Children's Literature, 2012, is to be presented to Jagdish Prasad Mandal for *Taregan*, his collection of inspirational children's microfiction, at the Videha Theatre Festival in 2013. *Taregan* received the largest number of votes. Three books were placed in online voting at www.videha.co.in: (1) Jagdish Prasad Mandal's *Taregan*; (2) Jivakant's *Khikhirak Bīari*; and (3) Murlidhar Jha's *Pilpilahā Gāchh*. In the experts' view, many pieces in *Pilpilahā Gāchh* could not be considered stories for children. It was therefore removed from the list, because this was specifically a children's literature award; in any case, it had also received the

fewest votes. Other works were not considered, since they were pamphlet-sized rather than book-length publications.

Tagore Literature Award 2011. The Sahitya Akademi's 2011 Tagore Literature Award for Maithili was conferred on Jagdish Prasad Mandal for his short-short-story collection *Gāmak Jingī*. The ceremony took place in Kochi on 12 June 2012.

There seems no prospect of the end of controversies surrounding Maithili. A person described here as a self-styled literary figure was chosen to prepare the shortlist for this award. According to information received, he proposed books on the basis of caste and narrow loyalties, omitting works by Nichiketa, Subhash Chandra Yadav, and Jagdish Prasad Mandal. The writer further reports that this shortlist-maker, Ajit Azad, told Videha's assistant editor Munnaji that Jagdish Prasad Mandal would never receive the Tagore Literature Award during his lifetime. When the referees sent seven recommendations, they included Chandranath Mishra "Amar"'s *Atīt Manthan*, although, according to this account, that book had not been published within the stipulated period, 2007–09. Were books being recommended without being read? The Sahitya Akademi should identify those who compile shortlists of this kind and those referees who recommend unread books, make their names public, and permanently bar them; only then, the writer argues, can Maithili's honour be protected. The account also states that the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili coordinator, Vidyanath Jha "Vidit," had neither informed nor congratulated Jagdish Prasad Mandal on receiving the prize, even after Mandal returned from accepting it. All India Radio, Darbhanga, reportedly broadcast nothing about this first Tagore Literature Award for Maithili, and Hindi newspapers in Darbhanga and Madhubani carried no reports, whereas the national English newspapers reported it without exception. The author presents this contrast as an exposure of the narrow caste-based outlook of these institutions and journalists. In his judgment, Jagdish Prasad Mandal's *Gāmak Jingī* is the finest collection of very short stories in the history of Maithili literature. Congratulations to Jagdish Prasad Mandal.

Vidyāpati and the *pāg* in the parallel tradition. A *maur* is made from *koḍhilā* and is distinct from the *pāg*. Among Karna Kayasthas too, the *pāg* is worn only for certain rites, such as *siddhānta* and *kumram*; for weddings they go wearing a *maur*, not a *pāg*. Among Brahmins in Purnia, a newly married woman goes to a banyan tree during *barsāit* wearing a *maur*. The *pāg*, the writer maintains, is exclusively a ritual symbol associated with marriage among Maithil Brahmins. Sanskrit works by Vidyāpati are attributed to "Thakur Vidyāpati," who, he argues, was Brahmin. My concern is with the Vidyāpati of the Maithili *Padāvalī*. Why was that poet made into "our Vidyāpati" by putting a *pāg* on his head? This did not happen during the eight hundred years in which non-Brahmin communities kept his legacy alive through *Vidāpat nāch*. It happened when Bengal appropriated the songs of

Vidyāpati and Govind Das, and the Bengali scholar Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay first asserted in 1875 that Vidyāpati was a poet of Mithila; Nagendranath Gupta of Bengal likewise first asserted that Govind Das was a poet of Mithila. Initially Bengal rose up in opposition, then accepted these conclusions. Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay was referring to the Vidyāpati of the *Padāvalī*; Bengal had never claimed the Sanskrit- and Avahaṭṭa-writing Vidyāpati Thakur as its own. The Maithili songs embedded in Jyotirishwar's Sanskrit play *Dhūrtasamāgama* and in the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa writer Vidyāpati's *Gorakṣavijaya* are further evidence of an older *Padāvalī* tradition and demonstrate its influence on both writers. Mithila's scholars then intervened: bringing together Vidyāpati's Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa books, the name Govind Das, and entries from genealogical registers, they produced the composite identities "Vidyāpati Thakur" and "Govind Das Jha" (!). The superficial genealogical knowledge and limited perspective of Ramanath Jha, according to this critique, caused damage here. Subsequently, the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad—an institution which, after Indian independence, placed a *pāg* on Vidyāpati's head and represented him as Brahmin—made the Maithili poet (not the Sanskrit author) into "our Vidyāpati" for the Brahmin community. But Kabir, Jyotirishwar, and many other poets appear in genealogical records too. Why, the author asks, is the variation in names so conspicuous for Vidyāpati, notwithstanding all the planning, but absent for Jyotirishwar? I have visited the worship of village deities in Purnia and seen the field where Ram Thakur, regarded as a divinity, was represented by a clod of earth: why was that place so illuminated? Carpenters (*baṛhī*) who migrated from Mithila to Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh were called "Jhaji" because they spoke Maithili; some now use Jha as a surname. In four or five villages of Maldah district, Bengal, Maithil Brahmins have the surname Ojha; those of Aligarh, the Prajgarh Maithils, use Sharma. How many Vidyāpatis are recorded in the genealogical registers? The early Vidyāpatis bear neither "Jha" nor "Thakur" in their names. The author asks, with irony, how Ramanath Jha could have found such an attribution.

Nowhere in the Maithili *Padāvalī* does its Vidyāpati identify himself as a writer of Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭa. Why is the pain he feels for the dispossessed absent from the writings of the other Vidyāpati, whom the author regards as a Brahmin writer of Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa? That other Vidyāpati, he argues, despises the proletariat and is sternly Brahminical in his written work; the poet of the *Padāvalī*, by contrast, is spontaneous and unaffected. A few harshly worded verses have been declared characteristic of him by rigid Brahminical editors, as though they could be treated as a convenient pretext. It is time for thoughtful readers to hear *Piyā Desāntar*, Vidyāpati's song of separation and migration, in concert; amid the distress currently suffered by Maithili migrants, this is respectfully dedicated to the great poet. Is that sorrow found in the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati?

Seven people honoured with the Maithili Talent Award at Rajbiraj. The Maithili Kavi Parishad, a branch of the Maithili Sahitya Parishad, formerly

presented this distinction as the Maithili Children's Talent Award. It was established by its president, Mahendra Mandal "Banwari." From this year it has been renamed the Maithili Talent Award. Recipients were the poet Sagar Vir Qadri; radio-drama performer Jibach Das; Bhupendra Mandal; singers Devendra Sah "Soni" and Shivshankar Yadav; and, for contributions to Maithili music, Ram Adhin Sah and Preeti Adhikari.

Subhash Chandra Yadav's *Banait–Bigrait*. The work illuminates the reasons for the resentment felt by certain caste-minded Maithili literary figures. Subhash Chandra Yadav does not betray the community from which he comes: he struggles for its problems and its language, refuses compromise, and shows ideological consistency—something the reviewer finds lacking in Taranand Viyogi. That, he alleges, is why Yadav incurred the displeasure of Mohan Bhardwaj, Yoganand Jha, Ramdev Jha, and others, whereas Taranand Viyogi and Mahendra Narayan Ram enjoyed acceptance. When the Maithili Lekhak Sangh organised a discussion of *Banait–Bigrait*, Ashok and Taranand Viyogi dared to present papers, but Yoganand Jha and Mohan Bhardwaj remained silent; Navendu Kumar Jha attended. Later I was astonished to see a report in *Vidyāpati Times*, which I describe as a blackmailing paper from Kabilpur. It bore a headline along the lines of "The Author of *Banait–Bigrait* Could Not Advance Beyond *Ghardekhiyā*—Mohan Bhardwaj," allegedly a report of that very Maithili Lekhak Sangh discussion. I took this as an exposure of Yoganand Jha's mentality. Mohan Bhardwaj has not denied the report, and I therefore infer that this falsehood was published with his consent. When *Ghar-Bahar* and *Mithila Darshan* began persistently advocating Sahitya Akademi awards for writers such as Mahendra Malingiya and Mohan Bhardwaj in Kamal Mohan Chamu's columns, I remembered *Vidyāpati Times* and perceived an entire conspiracy. Is this not a conspiracy against Subhash Chandra Yadav's *Banait–Bigrait*? When Amaresh Pathak, Chandranath Mishra "Amar," and Mayanand Mishra joined against Nichiketa's *No Entry Mā Viśva*, and the reactionary poet Udaychandra Jha "Vinod" was given the Akademi Award the preceding year, the situation seemed equally clear. Read *Banait–Bigrait*: http://sites.google.com/a/shruti-publication.com/shruti-publication/Home/Banait_Bigrait_SubhashChandraYadav.pdf?attredirects=0.

3. *Rajkamal Chaudhary: A Monograph* (Subhash Chandra Yadav), which, according to this account, could not be published by the Sahitya Akademi because of the intervention of Ramdev Jha and Mohan Bhardwaj.

https://docs.google.com/a/videha.com/viewer?a=v&pid=sites&srcid=dmlkZWhhLmNvbXx2aWRlaGEtcG9oaGl8Z3g6NDNiMmVhYThlOTNiMDA5Zg

Rajkamal Chaudhary: A Monograph (Subhash Chandra Yadav)—download link:
https://sites.google.com/a/videha.com/videha-pothi/Home/Rajkamal_Monograph.pdf?attredirects=0&d=1

Gangesh Gunjan: "I had heard of the Rajkamalji (monograph) episode, but so many years have now passed. How grave it was becomes clear from this Facebook exchange of yours. I thank you for bringing it out, Gajendraji. … The truth is that before I could finish reading it, my heart had become disenchanted. I could not read any further."

"Good that you put it on the internet! The contemporary generation and those yet to come should know this dark story. Think of the predicament of someone like me: everyone involved—young friends, contemporaries, elders—is personally connected with me. What a historical calamity this has become! I am not personally responsible from any direction, yet I am condemned to bear a sense of moral guilt on behalf of an entire literary generation. What is the remedy? With affection, 11 September 2012, 11:26."

Black-Marketing of the Coordinator's Position at the Sahitya Akademi: A Report

The organisations designated to select the Maithili coordinator of the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi are these: Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Darbhanga, whose secretary is Vaidyanath Chaudhary "Baiju" and president Pandit Chandranath Mishra "Amar"; Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad, Darbhanga, whose secretary is Dr Ganapati Mishra and whose late president was Jaymant Mishra; Chetna Samiti, Patna, with Vivekanand Thakur as secretary and Pramila Jha as president; an organisation in Rauti, Madhubani, probably then chaired by Hetukar Jha; Kishorikant Mishra's Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, which the author accuses of putting a *pāg* on Vidyāpati and declaring him Brahmin, and whose president is Surendra Narayan Jha and secretary Gangadhar Jha; and Panchanan Mishra's Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Samiti, Allahabad. The names and officeholders of some of these organisations may have changed. Most, the editorial contends, are either paper organisations or political rather than literary bodies, run on caste, regional, and hereditary lines.

Actions of the Editorial Board of *Ghar-Bahar* (Vasukinath Jha, Ramanand Jha "Raman," and Kamal Mohan Chamu), Whether Associated with or Tolerant of Caste-Based Theatre

Ghar-Bahar, July 2012: a Brahminical attitude, in the author's words, amounting to open support for theft. A person named Pankaj Parashar, accused here of theft, was given space in the column "Jug-Jug Jīvathu." In Mithila society, the author says, people of all twelve *varṇas* would drive out a thief; yet the editorial board of this Maithili literary journal openly sided with the accused because he belonged to their caste. The second example concerns Anand Kumar Jha's receipt of the Young Playwright Honour. The editors of what is described as caste-based theatre expressed resentment, without stating what objections had actually been made to the selection procedure. This, the

writer argues, is Brahminical blackmail: join the caste-based theatre, become its collaborator, or face intimidation.

Abusive Postcards and Emails from Vijaydev Jha or Shankardev Jha (the Third Generation of Chandranath Mishra "Amar" and Ramdev Jha)

This time the Maithili Children's Literature Award went to a book the author does not consider children's literature, Murlidhar Jha's *Pilpilahā Gāchh*. He alleges that Murlidhar Jha shamelessly accepted garlands and a *pāg*, while certain caste-minded people were equally shameless in bestowing them. This issue presents a report on the matter and examples of the insulting words ascribed to the third generation of Chandranath Mishra "Amar" and Ramdev Jha. The report brings together abusive emails and text messages. Anyone who has received abusive postcards or emails from Vijaydev Jha or Shankardev Jha —or what the author characterises as blackmailing newspaper and magazine reports or insulting SMS messages—is asked to send scanned copies or forwarded emails to ggajendra@videha.com. In the author's denunciation, these people, whom he says belong in prison, have used the Sahitya Akademi to intimidate Maithili literature for forty-five years, benefiting from a literary establishment he calls cowardly and casteist; that dominance, he declares, is ending. A newspaper report, described here as blackmail, allegedly refuses to recognise Nichiketa as Maithil. Nichiketa, Bhimnath Jha, and others bear indirect responsibility, the writer contends, because they listened to abuse and allowed the perpetrators' confidence to grow. Maithili journals, he argues, have been divided into Brahminical and Kayastha-aligned camps. Their differences are bitter, even violent in tone, yet they unite against Videha. Nichiketa's *Mithila Darshan*, in his assessment, has also become a Brahminical magazine. Its editor-in-chief cannot escape responsibility: he should reform his editorial board and encourage courage among its members.

Sukant Som's Unacknowledged Caste Bias

Sukant Som has published an article in *Mithila Darshan*. It contains, in the author's view, numerous factual errors. Som does not appear to know that *Atīt Manthan* was not published between 2007 and 2009. Nor could he acknowledge, as the writer does, that *Gāmak Jingī* is the finest collection of very short stories in Maithili literature. By suggesting indirectly that a prize must somehow be given to some booklet or other in Maithili, he revealed his intention. He represented a jury from Bhagalpur as though it were a Darbhanga jury, and in doing so apparently abandoned all pretence of impartiality. Som even thinks the award ceremony was held in Bangalore, whereas it was held in Kochi. He calls the Tagore Literature Award the Rabindra Award. His undeclared caste bias, the editorial concludes, speaks volumes.

Is Maithili Literature Brahminical in Its Essential Character?

(Based on the debate at Samnvay 2012, Indian Languages Festival, India Habitat Centre, Delhi)

Is Maithili literature Brahminical in its essential character?

My answer is both yes and no. If your judgment rests on the caste profiles of the authors appearing in *Mithila Darshan*, *Antika*, *Ghar-Bahar*—published by the Chetna Samiti, organiser of the *pāg*-centred Vidyāpati festivals—*Sanes* of Jharkhand, or *Jakhān-Takhān*, then the answer is yes. If you judge from the brazen use, for decades, of objectionable language by a caste-based theatre representing just two communities and designed to please its own audience, the answer is yes. If you judge from the caste profiles of all eight coordinators appointed to the Sahitya Akademi so far, the answer is yes. If you judge from the weak, poor compilations and programmes produced by CIIL, NBT, or the Sahitya Akademi, the answer is yes. If you judge from All India Radio, Darbhanga, or the Darbhanga editions of Hindi newspapers, again the answer is yes.

But consider the non-Brahmin, *pāg*-less Vidyāpati whom the writer places before Jyotirishwar and Shridhar Das; consider Gaṅgeśa, author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, of whom genealogical narratives claim that he was born five years after his father's death, married a woman of the leather-working community, and had his love poems made to disappear. Consider Bhojakwa FM, or Ramlakhan Sahu of Pakariya village near Phulwas (post office Ratansara), son of the late Khushilal Sahu, who has run a theatrical troupe for twenty-five years, exhausted ten bighas of land on it, and whose group gave perhaps a hundred performances at Durga Puja this year. If you see these, the answer is no. If All India Radio, Darbhanga, the local Hindi press, and the magazines described above do not recognise this as news, but publish annual celebrations of ordinary playwrights and interviews declaring Maithili theatre dead, that is their problem.

The performance traditions of *Vidāpat*, based on Vidyāpati's *Padāvalī*, and *Piyā Desāntar*, founded on its songs of migration and separation, have declined in number too. Yet if one compares their relative presence, the difference between mainstream and parallel traditions remains one to ninety-nine; on that measure, this is very much a non-Brahminical tradition.

> High on the mountain sleeps the bumblebee; the gardener's daughter sleeps amid the flowers, O!
>
> Awake, awake, O gardener's daughter; string a garland of *girmal* blossoms, O!

If Dhirendra "Premiś" hears this song from the *Śabdaśāstram* tradition as classical music rather than as a song of the proletariat, he can hear it uploaded in Videha Audio. It was recorded in the leather-workers' hamlet, the very settlement to which the song's story belongs; this is the triumph of the non-

Brahminical tradition. Which tradition of Vidyāpati do we mean—the one in which he upholds the *varṇāśrama* order, or the one in which he voices women's pain—"What austerity did I perform that I became a mother?"—or the poor person's sorrow, "Even in dreams I found no happiness"? The answer is the same. For the mainstream, the parallel tradition has always been a fashion. Jyotirishwar, and the Vidyāpati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa, likewise adopted it as a fashion in *Dhūrtasamāgama* and *Gorakṣavijaya*. Avahaṭṭa itself was a literary language, and dynamic figures of the mainstream drew upon the parallel tradition as a stylistic fashion. A people's poet or activist is not satisfied after writing two, four, ten, twenty-five, or fifty poems. Yet when this tradition is used as a fashion, it appears not only in Jyotirishwar and the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati, but also, the author argues, in the fashion-conscious dynamism of Yatri–Nagarjun's Maithili poetry. By contrast, the tradition of the earlier, *pāg*-less, non-Brahmin Vidyāpati is visible in *Vidāpat*, *Piyā Desāntar*, and the thousands of *jhā* and *mahājhā* compositions created by Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jhādūdār." If people like me write down and type only a few of them, the number still grows to a hundred or two hundred. Insert a poem extolling *varṇāśrama dharma* into the *Padāvalī*, sitting at the house of Loknath Jha in Tarauni, add the names Shiv Singh and Lakhima, and the rhythm of the pre-Jyotirishwar *Padāvalī* breaks. The *Vidāpat* and *Piyā Desāntar* troupes cannot perform or sing it; the conspiracy falls apart without further effort.

I have some disagreement with the goal of reaching the "diaspora community." The immediate work should be to bring this information into the communicative life of native speakers wherever they reside, acting as a spokesperson for the excluded, for women, and for the parallel tradition. As for Maithili print media, parallel writing occupies, by the author's reckoning, ninety per cent of the field in both quality and quantity. The internet is an added advantage. Four to five hundred Maithili books and ten thousand Maithili palm-leaf documents are available for free download as PDF or camera-ready copies in the Videha archive. In addition to Devanagari, the archive includes Maithili in Tirhuta and in what the source calls *tel*. Through Google and Videha, more than four hundred books are fully browsable and downloadable in Google Books. Among them are seven books or files comprising Maithili–English and English–Maithili dictionaries, released under the Creative Commons Attribution–ShareAlike licence. This means that anyone may use them with attribution, distribute adaptations under the same terms, expand and improve them, and even make commercial use of them.

The "diaspora community" is paying its debt to the native community. Native speakers have advanced far and think progressively; they recognise themselves in writing from the parallel tradition. The exhausted mainstream, by contrast, lags behind both in constructive direction and in time.

Is Maithili Only the Language of Maithil Brahmins?

What has the Centre for the Study of Indian Traditions to do with Maithili literature? Vidyapati Seva Sansthan and Chetna Samiti are political institutions: what do they do besides organise annual Vidyāpati festivals around the *pāg*-wearing Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati? Even the neighbours of the All India Maithili Sahitya Samiti do not know whether it exists. Why does that organisation retain its recognition after Jayakant Mishra's death? Are his daughter and son-in-law receiving compensation for his services to Maithili? What is the Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad? Why is an MBBS doctor with no literary involvement willing to lend his name and address to what the author calls a moribund body, so that it can retain voting rights? The Mithila Sanskritik Parishad is, in this account, responsible for displaying Vidyāpati in a *pāg* and ritually initiating not the poet but Maithili itself. Are these exclusively Maithil Brahmin organisations kept in existence merely to exercise votes, patronage, and control over the choice of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili convener in Delhi—and thereby to make Maithili a language belonging only to Maithil Brahmins?

Is Maithili Only the Language of Maithil Brahmins?

What answer emerges if one looks at the distribution of awards at the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi (!)?

(Total distribution, forty-three occasions through 2011): Maithil Brahmins—36 times! Kayasthas—5 times.

Rajputs—2 times; non-upper-caste recipients—0000 times!

The Chinese Writer Mo Yan

The Chinese author Mo Yan (pen name Mo Yan, birth name Guan Moye) is to receive the 2012 Nobel Prize in Literature, the Swedish Academy announced on 11 October 2012. At the press conference he was described as a writer whose combination of folktale, history, and contemporary events creates a waking, dreamlike reality. Mo Yan is the first citizen of China to receive the Nobel Prize in Literature. He was born in Shandong province in eastern China in 1955 to farming parents. At twelve, during the Cultural Revolution, he had to leave school and work first in agriculture and then in a factory. He later joined the People's Liberation Army. His first short story was published in 1981.

His writing evokes his childhood and birthplace, as in *Red Sorghum*, a novel also adapted into a film, with accounts of banditry, the Japanese occupation, and the tragic circumstances of agricultural labourers.

In addition to novels, collections of his short stories have appeared. Mo Yan says that the great novel still remains to be written.

Maithili

Was Lalu Prasad responsible for the removal of Maithili from the BPSC, or were Maithili's sectarian professors responsible? When Lalu Prasad first became Chief Minister, the results of the Bihar Administrative, Finance, and perhaps Forest Services examinations were printed in Hindi newspapers with candidates' names and surnames. The lists appeared to be full of successful Maithil Brahmin candidates; people were alarmed to see "Jha" repeated so often. Could a candidate obtain ninety per cent in Maithili literature while neglecting the normal calculation of marks? Subjects such as LSD and Geography sometimes also yielded very high marks in BPSC examinations, but not in the same way and not to the benefit of any one surname. The author alleges that examiners drawn largely from Maithili's professorial establishment produced this pattern. Pressure was brought to bear on Lalu Prasad for several days; his commitment to social justice was ridiculed, and eventually Maithili had to be removed from the BPSC examinations. Only then, the account claims, did he discover that the exclusion scarcely troubled ninety per cent of Maithil Brahmins. If even the two to four hundred people who entered the administrative, finance, or other services through Maithili became subscribers to a Maithili journal, those journals would not be in their present condition; yet ninety-nine per cent of them, the writer asserts, have no connection with Maithili today. History will not forgive the harm done to the language by the casteism of its sectarian mainstream professors.

Videha Honours

Videha Parallel Sahitya Akademi Honours

1. Videha Parallel Sahitya Akademi Fellowship Awards, 2010–11

2010: Govind Jha (for lifetime contribution).

2011: Ramanand Renu (for lifetime contribution).

2. Videha Parallel Sahitya Akademi Awards, 2011–12

2011, Main Award: Jagdish Prasad Mandal (*Gāmak Jingī*, short-story collection).

2011, Children's Literature Award: Lieutenant Colonel Mayanath Jha (*Jakar Nārī Chatur Hoi*, story collection).

2011, Youth Award: Anand Kumar Jha (*Kalah*, a play).

2012, Translation Award: Ramlochan Thakur (Maithili translation of *Padmanadīk Mājhī*, a Bengali novel by Manik Bandopadhyay).

Videha Language Honours, 2012–13 (Presented as an Alternative to the Sahitya Akademi Awards)

1. Videha Parallel Sahitya Akademi Fellowship Award, 2012

2012: Rajnandan Lal Das (for lifetime contribution).

2. Videha Language Honours, 2012–13 (presented as an alternative to the Sahitya Akademi Awards)

2012, Children's Literature Award: Jagdish Prasad Mandal, for his inspirational collection of children's microfiction, *Taregan*.

2012, Main Award: Rajdev Mandal, for his poetry collection *Ambarā*.

2012, Youth Award: Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary, for her poetry collection *Achins*.

2013, Translation Award: Naresh Kumar Vikal, for his Maithili translation of *Yayāti*, the Marathi novel by Vishnu Sakharam Khandekar.

Videha Language Honours, 2013–14 (Presented as an Alternative to the Sahitya Akademi Awards)

2013, Children's Literature Award: Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary, for *Devījī*, a collection of essays for children.

2013, Main Award: Bechan Thakur, for *Betīk Apamān ā Chhīnardevī*, a collection of plays.

2013, Youth Award: Umesh Mandal, for his poetry collection *Ninstukī*.

2014, Translation Award: Vineet Utpal, for his Maithili translation of *Mohandas*, the Hindi novel by Uday Prakash.

Announcement of the Videha Honours in Theatre, Song, Music, Dance, Sculpture, Craft and Painting, 2012

Acting—Lead Performance

Shilpi Kumari, age 17; father: Lakshman Jha.

Shobha Kant Mahto, age 15; father: Ramavatar Mahto.

Comic Acting

Priyanka Kumari, age 16; father: Vaidyanath Sah.

Dugdhanand Thakur, age 23; father: the late Bharat Thakur.

Dance

Sulekha Kumari, age 16; father: Hareram Yadav.

Amit Ranjan, age 18; father: Nageshwar Kamta.

Painting

Pankalal Mandal, age 35; father: the late Sundar Mandal; village: Chhajna.

Ramesh Kumar Bharti, age 23; father: Moti Mandal.

Music (Harmonium)

Parmanand Thakur, age 30; father: Nathuni Thakur.

Music (Dholak)

Bulan Raut, age 45; father: the late Chintu Raut.

Music (Rasanchauki)

Bahadur Ram, age 55; father: the late Sarjug Ram.

Crafts and Object-Making

Jagdish Malik, age 50; village: Chanauraganj.

Sculpture and Clay Modelling

Yadunandan Pandit, age 45; father: Ashfal Pandit.

Woodcraft

Jhameli Mukhiya, age 49; father: the late Mungalal Mukhiya; village: Chhajna.

Agriculture and Self-Reliant Culture

Lachhmi Das, age 50; father: the late Phani Das; village: Berma.

Videha Maithili Journalism Honour

2012: Navendu Kumar Jha.

Announcement of the Videha Honours in Theatre, Song, Music, Dance, Sculpture, Craft and Painting, 2013

Lead Acting

(1) Asha Kumari, daughter of Ramavatar Yadav, age 18; village and post office: Chanauraganj; language variety: Tamuria; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Mohammad Samsad Alam, son of Mohammad Isha Alam; village and post office: Chanauraganj; language variety: Tamuria; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(3) Arpana Kumari, daughter of Manoj Kumar Sahu, born 18 February 1998; village: Lakshminiya; post office: Chhajna; language variety: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Comic Acting

(1) Brahmadev Paswan, also known as Ramjani Paswan, son of the late Lakshmi Paswan; village and post office: Auraha; language variety: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Tofik Alam, son of Mohammad Samsad Alam; village and post office: Chanauraganj; language variety: Jhanjharpur; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Videha Honours in Theatre, Song, Music, Dance, Sculpture, Craft and Painting (Mangin Khabas Lifetime Contribution Honour)

Classical Music with Tanpura

Ramvriksha Singh, son of Aniruddha Singh, age 56; village: Phulwariya; post office: Babubarhi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Mangin Khabas Honour: Preservation of Mithila Folk Culture

Ramlakhan Sahu, son of the late Khushilal Sahu, age 65; village: Pakariya; post office: Ratansara; Phulparas subdivision, Madhubani.

Videha Honours in Theatre, Song, Music, Dance, Sculpture, Craft and Painting (Lifetime Contribution Honour)

Dance

(1) Harinarayan Mandal, son of the late Nandi Mandal, age 58; village and post office: Chhajna; language variety: Narihiya; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Sangeeta Kumari, daughter of Ramdev Paswan, age 16; village and post office: Chanauraganj; language variety: Jhanjharpur; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Painting

(1) Jay Prakash Mandal, son of Kusheshwar Mandal, age 35; village: Sanpathaha; post office: Bauraha; language variety: Saraigarh; Supaul district, Bihar.

(2) Chandan Kumar Mandal, son of Bhola Mandal; village: Khargapur; post office: Belahi; language variety: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar. Revised entry: final-year undergraduate student at the College of Arts and Crafts, Patna.

Harmonium / Harmonium

(1) Mahadev Sah, son of Ramdev Sah, age 58; Belaha, Ward 09; post office: Chhajna; language variety: Narihiya; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Jageshwar Prasad Raut, son of the late Samrup Raut, age 60; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

Dholak / Dholak Players

(1) Anup Sadai, son of a deceased father (name not given); village: Tulsiyahi; post office: Manohar Parhi; police station: Marauna; Supaul district, Bihar.

(2) Kalkar Ram, son of the late Khattar Ram, age 50; village: Lakshminiya; post office: Chhajna; language variety: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Rasanchauki Performers

(1) Babudev Ram, son of the late Anup Ram; village and post office: Nimli, Ward 07; Supaul district, Bihar.

Crafts and Object-Making

(1) Bauku Malik, son of Darbari Malik, age 70; village: Lakshminiya; post office: Chhajna; language variety: Narihiya; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Ramvilas Dharikar, son of the late Thodhai Dharikar, age 40; village and post office: Chanauraganj; language variety: Tamuria; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Sculpture and Clay Modelling

(1) Ghuran Pandit, son of Mohanu Pandit; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Bhushan Pandit, son of a deceased father (name not given); village and post office: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Woodcraft

(1) Jagdev Sahu, son of Shanichar Sahu, age 36; village: Nimli-Purwas; Supaul district, Bihar.

(2) Yogendra Thakur, son of the late Buddhu Thakur, age 45; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

Agriculture and Self-Reliant Culture

(1) Ramavatar Raut, son of the late Sukhad Raut, age 66; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

(2) Roshan Yadav, son of the late Kapileshwar Yadav, age 35; village and post office: Bangama; language variety: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Anhār / Mahrār

(1) Mohammad Jibach, son of the late Mohammad Bilat, age 65; village: Basaha; post office: Barhara; language variety: Andhratharhi; Madhubani district, PIN 847401.

Jogirā

Bakshan Mandal, son of the late Sitaram Mandal, age 60; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

Ramdev Thakur, son of the late Jageshwar Thakur, age 50; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

Parātī (Pramātī) Singers and Khajarī/Khaujarī Performers

(1) Sukdev Safi, son of a father whose name is not supplied; village: Itahari; post office: Belahi; language variety: Nimli; police station: Marauna; Supaul district, Bihar.

Parātī (Pramātī) Singers (Singing from Agahan through Māgh–Phāgun)

(1) Sukdev Safi, son of the late Babunath Safi, age 75; village: Itahari; post office: Belahi; language variety: Nimli; police station: Marauna; Supaul district, Bihar.

(2) Lekhu Das, son of the late Sanak Mandal; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

Jharanī

(1) Mohammad Gul Hasan, son of the late Abdul Rashid; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

(2) Mohammad Rahman Sahab, age 58; village: Narihiya; language variety: Phulparas; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Nāl Players

(1) Jagat Narayan Mandal, son of the late Khushilal Mandal, age 40; village and post office: Kakardobh; language variety: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Dev Narayan Yadav, son of Kushumlāl Yadav; village: Banarjhula; post office: Amhi; police station: Ghoghardiha; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Gīthārī / Folk Songs

(1) Phudni Devi, wife of Ramphal Mandal; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

(2) Suvita Kumari, daughter of Gangaram Mandal, age 18; village: Machhadhi; post office: Baliyari; language variety: Jhanjharpur; Madhubani district, Bihar.

Khuradak Players

(1) Sitaram Ram, son of the late Jangal Ram, age 52; village: Lakshminiya; post office: Chhajna; language variety: Narihiya; police station: Laukahi; Madhubani district, Bihar.

(2) Lakshmi Ram, son of the late Panchu Mochi, age 70; village and post office: Berma; language variety: Tamuria; police station: Jhanjharpur (R.S. Camp); Madhubani district, PIN 847410, Bihar.

Ghazal Kamla–Kosi–Bagmati–Mahananda Honour

The "Ghazal Kamla–Kosi–Bagmati–Mahananda Honour" for 2011, sponsored by *Anchinhar Akhar* (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com), was presented to Ustad Sadre Alam Gauhar. The chief selector that year was Ustad Siyaram Jha "Saras."

The "Ghazal Kamla–Kosi–Bagmati–Mahananda Honour" for 2012 (Ghazal), sponsored by *Anchinhar Akhar* (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com), was presented to Ustad Pankaj Chaudhary ("Naval Shri"). The chief selector was Jagdish Chandra Thakur "Anil."

The "Ghazal Kamla–Kosi–Bagmati–Mahananda Honour" for 2012 (Children's Ghazal), sponsored by *Anchinhar Akhar* (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com), was presented to Ira Malik. The chief selector was Preeti Thakur.

The "Ghazal Kamla–Kosi–Bagmati–Mahananda Honour" for 2012 (Criticism and Review), sponsored by *Anchinhar Akhar* (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com), was presented to Omprakash. The chief selector was Rajdev Mandal.

Videha has entered every household. I want, by the morning of 1 June 2014, the list of all those Brahmin pseudo-storytellers who participated in the "Rāṛkeṃ Sukh Balāy" story gathering of Raman–Darihare–Bihari on 31 May 2014.

2. Now let us turn to the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili branch and the sham organisations it recognises, which have sought to bring *Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray* to an end.

3. Raman has, according to the author, received assignments worth lakhs of rupees from the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili branch over several years. He was entrusted with eliminating Videha's influence over *Sagar Rāti*, just as, the author alleges, he had earlier joined Bihari and Darihare in eliminating Aarti Kumari from the scene. This time his calculations went wrong. Maithili now had readers, strength, and standards, something the mediocre Raman–Bihari–Darihare could not understand. Blood brings its own colour and leaves recognisable traces … blood seeks out the person who shed it.

In Mithila, Durga Puja is generally organised by collecting contributions. Now people have begun stopping passers-by to collect donations for Saraswati

Puja too; that did not happen earlier, for the observance was connected with personal devotion. Nor will that devotion be found in Vidyāpati festivals that amount to garlanding an image, produced without any study of the poet's contemporary dress, showing him foolishly with a moustache or clean-shaven and, of course, wearing a *pāg*, as though a caste-minded artist could perform Vidyāpati's sacred-thread ceremony. Have these Vidyāpati festivals, caste-based theatre, the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili branch, Pragya Sansthan, Sajha Prakashan, and *Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray* increased or diminished communal rigidity in Maithili?

2. Vishwakarma Puja and Durga Puja make no claim to be working on behalf of Maithili, but they teach people how to cooperate in society. By contrast, the politics of gaining control of cultural institutions through the symbolic sacred-thread ceremony of Vidyāpati entered caste-based theatre and pushed Kolkata's Kurmi–Kshatriya community away from Maithili. Booklets and honours came to be reserved for Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas. If anyone else dared to intervene, older figures would encourage unruly young men by declaring them literary artists. The encouragement given to the author of "Rāṛkeṃ Sukh Balāy" by Shyam Darihare, Pradip Bihari, and Ramanand Jha "Raman" is, the editorial says, a fresh example. But how did this process, which for fifty years had functioned as a life-giving medicine for Brahminism and Kayastha dominance in Maithili, come crashing down? What is happening in Maithili literature, what historical action and reaction have made this possible, and why have Raman, Bihari, Darihare, their patrons in the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili department, and caste-based theatre failed to understand it?

3. When the communal rigidity being instilled among Brahmin youths through *Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray* was challenged, Bihari, Raman, Darihare, and their patrons could not comprehend what was happening and ultimately lost patience. This time the world itself had turned upside down.

At the Rahua Sangram fiction gathering, all the participants, including Ramanji, decided that nobody would sleep through the night. Yet, before the meal, the readings by all the celebrated (!!) storytellers took place, and then those writers went to sleep. The turn of the young people who had listened to these famous writers came at daybreak. When Ashish Anchinhar arrived to read his story, the compère was nodding off, and only the chair, Shivshankar Srinivas, remained awake. Ramanji, who had agreed not to sleep, was snoring. In protest, Ashish Anchinhar refused to read, even after the chair requested him to do so. The postmodern story was later published in *Videha Laghu Kathā*.

But, the editorial argues, Brahminical censorship is so powerful that neither the organisers nor the histories of *Sagar Rāti* produced by Raman or the chair and compère mention this incident. The inclination to cover up disagreeable facts, it says, is the reason.

People ask me whether eighty-one *Sagar Rāti* gatherings really took place. Earlier, stories would arrive by post and the allegedly famous writers' stories were read. Young people who attended in person often received no turn at all; even when they did, their turn came after everyone had fallen asleep. When Munnaji protested, he was told to keep quiet. The attendance registers even included the names of those who had not come. At many fiction gatherings not even ten storytellers attended, yet the register would list a great many people: some never arrived, some supposedly "arrived by post," and some signed their attendance before disappearing. Just as, the author remarks satirically, a conflict with fewer than three thousand dead supposedly does not count as a war, how can a gathering with fewer than ten participants count as an all-night literary session? The tally of eighty-one would shrink considerably. Eighty-one is an immense number; a quiet revolution could have taken place in so many sessions. The reasons why it did not have already been explained.

In this parallel movement, I ask for either support or opposition. The "ideological neutrality" of Dhanakar Thakur and Gangesh Gunjan, to my mind, amounts to the same thing: opposition to the parallel current.

History will judge me too, and it will judge them—the opponents and the neutral fifth-columnists.

For six years, many people have said things like, "Videha has changed now; it has become just like them." Videha's purpose has not changed and will not change. Such comments are made without specifying whose interpretation is intended to appease whom. If their expectation was that the enthusiasm of young people would find a new direction in Maithili literature through Videha, but they now feel that it has become a platform for personal frustrations and misuse, my answer is this: truth can be used or misused by anyone. What strikes them now as misuse or the satisfaction of personal grudges had struck many others that way even six years ago. My explanation is that they expected Videha to offer only symbolic protest; those who do not really want change recognise genuine change as a threat to Brahminism, for a change in the people taking part has unsettled an inherited sense of entitlement: "If they went, we would have come—but who are these people who have come instead?" They should understand that Maithili has moved forward. Each person with ability has learned and advanced, to the extent of that ability, through Videha, and will continue to do so. Some became associated with Videha for selfish reasons, but their belief in hereditary caste superiority did not vanish despite Videha's sincere efforts. They regarded Videha as a literary movement—though not from the heart—and then resorted to emotional blackmail, threats, abusive emails and telephone calls to me and my family, and threats to leave. By coincidence, so far those threatening to leave have all been Brahmins who apparently assumed Videha would restrict itself to symbolic protest. For six years I have heard the same remarks: "Now you have become just like them! I know—it is for prizes; you

want an award given to so-and-so; it is personal politics; Videha will not benefit." I am tired of hearing it. Earlier, Ramdev Jha and Amar used to say that I was trying to secure an award for my wife. Everyone laughed and said that the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili department was itself exposed and had no standing to honour anybody else. Now the accusation is that I want prizes awarded to Umesh Mandal, Rajdev Mandal, and Bechan Thakur. Mohan Bhardwaj says before Devshankar Naveen that Gajendra Thakur is mad, just as Lakhan Jha was. Darihare is apparently very perceptive too: he now thinks the reason is my dispute with the Sahitya Akademi, merely personal politics. Bihari telephones Munnaji and asks why only Jagdish Mandal is being advanced (!). That is the Brahminical assumption: that Jagdish Mandal has progressed not through merit but through patronage, as things used to happen in Maithili literature. Pradip Bihari asks Munnaji why Videha opposes caste-based theatre and why a parallel tradition reviews the quality of the mainstream tradition. "The parallel does not even resemble the mainstream," he says in the account; "why mention our names? Stay apart." That, to the author, is the essence of Brahminism and Kayastha dominance: do not discuss us, do not even hear what we say. It is also, he observes, a coincidence that the few people who object all have Brahminical tendencies; why do others not feel similarly troubled? Videha will remain what it has been for the last six years, and for at least the next thirty years Maithili literature will proceed along these lines. In Videha, everyone will advance according to merit, whatever their caste, religion, or region. Those who think Videha has changed should ask themselves whether they are the ones who have changed.

Let us return now to *Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray*.

Many manoeuvres were carried out in the name of an unwritten constitution. This is principally a gathering for reading stories, though critical essays may also be read—provided, it seems, that one's name is Raman. When Munnaji asked permission to read a paper on microfiction at the Kabilpur gathering, permission was refused and the unwritten constitution was invoked. There were two reasons, the author says: Munnaji was not named Raman, and the concept of microfiction was being promoted by Videha, so it had to be opposed, however scientifically defensible it might be.

At the Jhanjharpur gathering, the stories of those who attended were not read, whereas stories received by post were read. And if you are Avinash, who abuses Suman and Amar in Yatri's name, then you too are a storyteller and a poet—even if you are neither—and, as a bonus, you may be given the convenership of the Deoghar gathering. At the Ghoghardiha gathering, the young people whose stories had been excluded protested. Some were then permitted to read; those still denied a turn stopped attending subsequent fiction gatherings.

Those who, according to the editorial, cheated people of money in the name of Maithili films and documentaries are allies of Raman, Darihare, and Bihari in their opposition to Videha. A young person who wrote in Maithili for the

sake of a prize and secured a Sahitya Akademi Youth Award through the caste-based establishment would naturally be their ally too, the writer argues.

It is alleged that Videha is using Umesh Mandal and Jagdish Prasad Mandal as shields, as though resting a gun on their shoulders; perhaps everything would have been considered acceptable had their work been suppressed before *Til Bahab Ne* appeared. Videha does not, like the Brahminical establishment in the author's view, require a prior bargain about *Til Bahab Ne* before undertaking literary work. The new adherents of that establishment could not understand this: how could people come together merely in the name of Maithili, without prior acquaintance, personal meetings, or social obligations? It struck them as extraordinary.

Pradip Bihari tells Munnaji—and Ramdev Jha reportedly shares the view—that now Videha has instituted awards parallel to those of the Sahitya Akademi, why make any more noise about the Akademi? In other words, leave it alone! Ashok Avichal tells Shivkumarji that Mayanath Jha, Anand Kumar Jha, and others discussed by Videha—one could add Gunanath Jha—have received Sahitya Akademi awards. The reply he reportedly received was this: had their surnames been Mandal instead of Jha, would that have been possible?

The Sahitya Akademi is neither a person with whom one might arrange a family reconciliation nor anyone's inherited property, available to distribute patronage to self-styled Brahmin and Kayastha literary figures.

Once they understood that I was not one of them, that Videha was not like them, they grew still more anxious. "Surely," they wondered, "he too must be one of us; perhaps he wants to take a prize for himself or have it awarded to somebody else …"

Brahminism has engulfed Maithili. But everybody knows that even two children of the same parents do not have identical characters. Videha does not believe that every member of an entire caste is either good or bad. That generalisation is itself a Brahminical concept, the author argues.

Atuleshwar Jha used to oppose Brahminism, but parted company after my article on the *pāg* and Vidyāpati. Many others have done likewise. Prem Chandra Pankaj and Abhay Das developed an aversion to Videha over one issue or another, and told Munnaji that they had stopped reading it. Yet they apparently continue reading it in secret, since they remain informed about all its activities.

Now return to *Sagar Rāti*. Those who hurled abuse at Suman and Amar on Yatri's behalf, and those who hurled abuse at Yatri on Amar and Suman's behalf, have, the editorial concludes, joined Darihare, Raman, and Bihari in opposing Videha so as to fight a final battle to preserve Brahminism in Maithili literature.

94. Gajendra Thakur is the editor of the journal Videha (http://www.videha.co.in/; ISSN 2229-547X) and currently resides in Delhi.

Abstract

Vidyāpati, the earliest poet of Maithili (before Jyotirīśvara). In Vidyāpati's Sanskrit works the attribution reads "composed by Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati," and that Vidyāpati was a Brahmin. My concern, however, is with the Vidyāpati of Maithili poetry. I have examined why he was crowned with the pāg and appropriated as "our Vidyāpati." This did not occur while non-Brahmin communities kept him alive for some eight centuries through the Bidāpat dance. It happened after Bengal had claimed Vidyāpati and Govindadāsa, and after the Bengali scholar Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay first argued that Vidyāpati was a poet of Mithila's language, while Nagendranath Gupta, also of Bengal, first maintained that Govindadāsa too was a poet of Mithila's language. When these findings came to light, Bengal initially protested vehemently, but eventually accepted them.

Keywords: Videha · journal · http · www · videha · co · in · ISSN

Abstract

This chapter considers the argument introduced by the statement that Gajendra Thakur edits the journal Videha (http://www.videha.co.in/; ISSN 2229-547X) and currently lives in Delhi. The Sanskrit works say "composed by Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati"; that Vidyāpati was a Brahmin. My concern is with the Maithili Vidyāpati and the question of why he was crowned with a pāg and claimed as "our Vidyāpati." That did not happen during the eight centuries when non-Brahmin communities preserved his memory through Bidāpat dance, but when Bengal laid claim to Vidyāpati and Govindadāsa, and the Bengali scholars Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay and Nagendranath Gupta identified the two respectively as poets of Mithila's language. Initially Bengal protested vehemently ...

Vidyāpati, the Earliest Poet of Maithili (Before Jyotirīśvara)

Vidyāpati: Refuting Certain Widely Circulated Misrepresentations

Vidyāpati in the Parallel Tradition and the Pāg

In the Sanskrit books attributed to Vidyāpati, the formula is "composed by Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati"; that Vidyāpati was a Brahmin. My concern is with the Vidyāpati of Maithili poetry and why a pāg was put on his head so that he could be made "our Vidyāpati." This did not happen during the eight hundred years in which non-Brahmin communities preserved his living memory through Bidāpat dance. It happened when Bengal came to claim the poems of Vidyāpati and Govindadāsa, and when the Bengali scholar Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay first declared Vidyāpati a poet of Mithila's language, while Nagendranath Gupta of Bengal first declared Govindadāsa a poet of that same language. At first Bengal reacted indignantly to these findings; later it accepted them. Scholars in Mithila then became interested and, bringing forward Vidyāpati's Sanskrit works and entries in the pañjī under the names Govindadāsa and Vidyāpati, manufactured a "Vidyāpati Thakur" and a

"Govindadāsa Jha" (!!!). Ramanath Jha's superficial knowledge of the pañjī and restricted perspective did damage here. Suddenly the Brahmin establishment put a pāg on Vidyāpati—the Maithili poet, not the Sanskrit author—and made him "our Vidyāpati." Some even began to call him a nephew of Jyotirīśvara!

Yet numerous poets bearing names like Kaviśvara Jyotirīśvara are recorded in the pañjī. Why does the discrepancy between names arise in the case of Vidyāpati—although, the author contends, everything was planned and one piece of evidence nevertheless survived—but not in the case of Jyotirīśvara?

Rām Ṭhākur

Why go all the way to Bengal? I attended the worship of a village deity in Purnia and saw Rām Ṭhākur (regarded as a god) represented as a deity by a lump of earth in a field. Someone had lit a lamp there.

People went from Mithila to Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh. Prabhat Jha, a Rajya Sabha member from Madhya Pradesh, related that when carpenters (baṛhī) migrated from Mithila, people called them "Jha-ji" because they spoke Maithili; they subsequently adopted Jha as a surname. Prabhat Jha campaigned for them, and a candidate won by a single vote. We all know from experience that, whatever a person's original title, even as far as Patna people may address a Maithili speaker as "Jha-ji" or "Jhauā." In four or five villages of Malda district, Bengal, the surname of Maithil Brahmins is Ojha; in Aligarh, the Maithil Brahmins known as Brajastha Maithils use Sharma.

How Many Vidyāpatis Appear in the Pañjī?

The pañjī includes the following entries referring to persons named Vidyāpati; personal names, places, numerals and the register's shorthand are preserved in transliteration, because the unexplained sigla cannot safely be expanded.
1. panicobha sā vidyāpatisuta ramāpatika vivāha vidyāpatika- mātā (devadāsī)-dūṣaṇa paṃjī
2. maho keśavo suta ma. ma. pāō govinda sutā maho lakṣmīnātha ma. ma. vidyāpati ma. ma. dāmodara
3. mahāmaho vidyāpati gaṃgolī sā mānakuḍha vāsī kavirāja gaṇeśvara
4. ghosotasā ma. ma. govinda sutā ma. lakṣmīdhara ma. ma. vidyāpati
5. rājapaṇḍita ma. ma. u. vidyāpati
6. karamahāsā devanātha suta kavi vidyāpati
7. guṇapatisantati-paṭhoṅagī) . . vidyāpati-puḍarīka-machadī. keśava-amarāvatī.
8. . . siṃhāśrama sāvidyāpati ddauo bhāgīratha sutau kuleśvara:
9. sidhūka: e sutā delhana viśvanātha śrīnāthā: siṃhāśrama sā vidyāpati dau. .
10. miśra jayadeva (76/06) sutā nagavāḍa ghosota sā mahāmahopādhyāya vidyāpati dau
11. mahāmahopādhyāya govinda sutā mahāmaho lakṣmīnāthā paranāmaka (209/05) ṭhakarū mao mao upāo vidyāpati
12. ddauo. . evam ṭhao vidyāpati mātṛka cakraṃ. .
13. mahomahopādhyāya vidyāpati sutā anirūddha ananta acyutā: ekaharā sā kāśī dau
14. saduosupe sutau dāmodara: e sutau ḍālūka: pavaulīsā goḍhi dau ḍālū (34/06) suto vidyāpati
15. sutā śirū padama lākhū gādūkā: ekaharā sā śrī kara suta cānda dau khauāla sā bhūle ddauo madhusūdana sutā umāpati (84/01) vidyāpati
16. musai sutā khauāla sā ḍālū suta vidyāpati dau bhaṇḍārisama sā śubhe ddauo ṭhao

17. sodarapura sā choṭāī dau (28/08) basāuna sutā paśupati vidyāpati
18. kalyāṇa sutā karamahā sā vidyāpati dau
19. jālaya sā rāmeśvarasuta mahighara dau yamugāma sā geṇāī ddauo vidyāpati suto bhagīratha:
20. harakhū govindā sakao guṇe suta vidyāpati dau suragana sā hore ddauo
21. kṛṣṇapati sutā murāri vidyāpati prajāpati ṭakabāla sā rāmakara dau. .
22. kavindra padāṃkita mao mao uo raghunāthā karamahā sā vidyāpati dau
23. suto vidyāpati māṇḍarasā yagyapati dau
24. talhanapura sā gaḍhavaya ddau. vidyāpati
25. yaśu suto ravipati rūdrapati vidyāpati candrapati
26. narauna sā vidyāpati dau
27. ravipati suto kṛṣṇapati vidyāpati ghusauta sā hore dau. .
28. vidyāpati sutā belaũca sārāma dau
29. guṇe suta gaurīpati vidyāpati lakṣmīpati kulapatiya: dario divākara dau
30. mahipati jhāka mātāmaha kavi kokila vidyāpati ṭhākara) dāmodara suto pāśadu. harideva: naraunasā māṅani dau
31. gaṇapati suto kavi kokila rājapaṇḍita mao mao upāovidyāpati: e sutau haripati dhanapati. .
32. mahāmahopādhyāya vidyāpatisutā hṛṣikeśa
33. harapati sutā vidyāpati kāśī dāmodarā:
34. ratipati sutā sodarao vidyāpati dau
35. vidyāpati prapautra pautra hariśvara dhaneśvara suto gondūka pālīsā jñānadau. .
36. vidyāpati ddau. veṇī suto ravinātha:
37. sodarao vidyāpati ddauo nikāra
38. śrīpati suto vidyāpati parānau dariharā
39. sodarao vidyāpati ddauo miśra kamalanayana sutā hariama sā bachāī dau
40. ravauālasā sone dau devanātha suto kavi vidyāpati pacahī sodarapurasā jagannātha dau
41. gopī suto vidyāpati vācaspati śīvā hariamasā nārāyaṇa dau. .
42. vidyāpati nidhi pra. dharāpatiya:
43. taraunī karamahāsā mahidhara dau. . (46/03) vidyāpati (111/03) suto madhusūdana:
44. kulānanda hṛdayanandano kara. panāī dau (109//106) vidyāpati (314/05) sutā pritinātha śobhanātha mahināthā:
45. ũmāpati suta vidyāpati suto jayapati:
46. jāgū sutā surapati haripati prabhāpati girapati vidyāpatiya:
47. hacalū sutā harapati vidyāpati maho jñānapati dinapati maṇikaṃṭhā
48. kṛṣṇa sutā ramāpati śrīpati ratnapati vidyāpati: būdhavāla sā dhīrū dau. .
49. dāśe sutā dayorī khaṇḍabalā sā gopīnātha dau (85//02) vidyāpati suta jīvanātha
50. narauna sā vidyāpati ddauo
51. dharmādhika raṇika bāṭū suto vidyāpati
52. sodarapura sā gayana dau vidyāpati sutā ramāpati horila hararavū jivāīkā māṇḍara sā soḍhū dau. .
53. khauāla sā raghunātha dau (54//07) vidyāpati suta jānū
54. ṭakabālasā vidyāpati ddau matinātha
55. khaṇḍabalāsā vidyāpati suta jīvanātha dau
56. karamahā sā vidyāpati ddauo viśvanātha
57. kṛṣṇapati suto ũmāpati (bao 28/01) vidyāpati (302/03) paṇḍuā sā pā᷄bhagīratha dau
58. maho harikṛṣṇa sutā khauāla sā vidyāpati dau
59. madhusūdana suto vidyāpati: alaya sā anirūddha dau
60. māṇḍara sā devaśarmma ddauo vidyāpati sutā narauna sā badanī dau
61. ṭhao śyāma sutopurandara paramānando māṇḍara sā vidyāpati dau
62. vidyāpati sutā sodarapura sā jayarāma
63. dharmeśvarau khauāla sā harāī suta manohara dau rūda suto rāma: gaṃgolī sā deve dau visphī sā kavi kokila rāja paṇḍita mao mao pāo vidyāpati ddauo rāma suto bhiravūka: phanandaha sā locana dau pakaliyā sā dinū ddauo bhiravū suto harāika: sodarapura sā vira

suta haridau khauāla sā śubhe ddauo harāī sutā mohana manoharā kamala nārāyaṇā: sodarapura sā jagannātha suta bhavānī dau bhavānī suto harideva sadāyakau hariama sā govinda suta śrīdhara dau sakao jāge ddauo manohara sutā karamahā sā ratanapati suta kṛṣṇadāśa dau kṛṣṇadāśa sutā sodarapura sā madhusūdana suta sundara dau (47//05) dariharā sā muśāī ddauo hari suto prāṇapati: sodarapura sā nārāyaṇa suta nanū dau (110//01) (101//01) nārāyaṇa suto nanūka: vudhavāla sā bahuḍī dau (180/04) dāmodara suto bahuḍīka: sodarapura sā paramānanda suta kāṃgava dau paramānanda suto kāṃgava: māṇḍara sā halaghara suta pītāmbara dau (58//05) karamahā sā śrīrāma ddauo kāṃgava sutā karamahā sā śivadeva suta kārama dau māṇḍara sā vāvū dauhitra dauo
64. vāvū durgāpati siṃha: suto vāvū vidyāpati siṃha: karamahā sā harinātha suta tārānātha dau
65. khauāla sā yuvarāja ddauo bāvū vidyāpati siṃha suto vāvū girijāpati siṃha
66. vāvū gaṃgāpati siṃha sutā bheṣapati siṃha vidyāpati siṃha
67. vāvū bheṣapati siṃha patnī antarjātīya e suta haṃsapati siṃha: vāvū vidyāpati siṃha suto ramana kumāra siṃha:
68. bālā suto bhaiyā kalyāṇau khauāla sā vidyāpati dau
69. viśvanātha kāśīnāthā: alaya sā vidyāpati dau
70. pāṭhaka vidyāpati suto dukhamaṃjana kalarau āsī ekaharā sā ūmānanda dau
71. narapati sutā kalyāṇapura visphī sā sundara dau kamalanayana suta nārāyaṇa suto sundara: karamahā sā vidyāpati dau
72. murāri sutā dāmodara vidyāpati mahighara ānandā:
73. vidyāpati sutā padmāpati sabhāpati ādipati gaṇapatiya: . .
74. vidyāpati suto chītū paramānando māṇḍara sā narapati dau baherāḍhī sā gadādhara ddauo
75. alaya sā kamala suta nakaṭū dau. vidyāpati suta jīvanātha suto parama: dari. rāma dau. .
76. karamahā sā vidyāpati suta madhusūdana dau
77. mānī sodarapura sā vācaspati suta vidyāpati dau
78. khaṇḍabalā sā vāvū durgāpati siṃha suta vāvū vidyāpati siṃha dau
79. khauāla sā vidyāpati dau ṭha. madhurāpati suto vācha śivānandano
80. sodarapura sā baidyanātha ddau. harikṛṣṇa sutā khauāla sā madhusūdanasuta vidyāpati dau
81. madhusūdana suta vidyāpati dau
82. dariharā sā ramāpati suta veṇī dau alaya sā kṛṣṇapati suta vidyāpati ddau
83. alaya sā vidyāpati ddau. ॥
84. jyo. śivanandana suto vidyāpati.
85. khauāla sā bhavadeva suta vidyāpati dau.
86. pāṭhaka kṛṣṇapati suto uṣāpati vidyāpati.
87. vidyāpati suto dukhabhaṃjana kalaro ekaharā sā devānanda suta ūmānanda dau
88. alaya sā vidyāpati suta kalaru dau
89. kāru sutā pitāmbara vidyāpati devakīmānā kā sodarapura sā vaidayanātha suta jayi dau
90. suroi pra. śāradānanda sutā gaurīnandana vācaspati pra. vidyāpati divākara pra. mandū ratnākara pra. bhra. bholana jī kā naga. ghusauta sā dāmodara suta ugramohana dau ekaharā sā śobhānanda ddau.
91. khauāla sā vidyāpati dau.

Let Us Return to the Central Issue

I have no doubt that the many court-paṇḍits and other holders of religious authority named Vidyāpati, one of whom was also the son of a devadāsī, were Brahmins. I am not discussing Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati, the Kīrtilatā or the Kīrtipatākā, but the Vidyāpati of the Padāvalī. We must not confuse the two. Let us turn to the Bidāpat tradition performed by non-Brahmins, whose poet,

I argue, belonged perhaps to the barber caste and lived before Jyotirīśvara; Jyotirīśvara's Varṇaratnākara describes both this poet and his work.

Mahādeva was originally a deity of non-Brahmins and was gradually adopted by Brahmins. Nowhere in the songs of the Padāvalī does its Vidyāpati claim authorship of Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭa works. Why, then, does the compassion for the dispossessed that suffuses these songs not appear in the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa compositions attributed to the other, Brahmin Vidyāpati? Consider the examples.

Vidyāpati's Bidesiyā: Piyā Desāntar and Bidāpat Dance

Bhojpuri literature is less extensive in quantity than Maithili literature, but in some respects it is more accomplished in quality. I am speaking particularly of Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiyā. Thakur was a migrant worker in Calcutta. Returning to his native Bhojpur region, he moved from village to village, singing and recounting his suffering with such poignancy that it became the play Bidesiyā. Migration is a contemporary phenomenon in Mithila; whole villages have fallen silent, and migrants from Mithila are scattered across the country. In an earlier period, however, the region did not experience migration of the same sort as Bhojpur. Movement largely extended to Morang, a part of Nepal's Mithila region. One consequence, I suggest, is the relative scarcity of minute folkloric accounts in Maithili: even the surviving narratives tend to present their heroes in an epic, ponderous manner rather than with the immediacy of Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiyā. Take the Salhes cycle. As the telling crosses regional boundaries, Salhes changes from king to thief and from thief to king. Chuharmal similarly becomes a thief where Salhes is a king, and a king or powerful figure where Salhes is called a thief. Such variations have received scarcely any research. Searching through Vidyāpati's Padāvalī, I encountered many kinds of songs. Most describe the longing of lovers separated from one another, not the fundamental condition of the bidesiyā: reluctant migration in search of livelihood and daily bread. Eventually I found a few songs genuinely concerned with the bidesiyā, whom Vidyāpati calls piyā desāntar, the beloved who has gone to another land. Most, understandably, came from the Nepal Padāvalī of Vidyāpati; one came from the Padāvalī collected by Nagendranath Gupta. Morang, situated in Nepal's Mithila, was associated with migration, which may explain this distribution.

On this basis Vidyāpati's Piyā Desāntar used to be enacted on stage.

Bidāpat Nāch and Piyā Desāntar are thus two dramatic forms founded on songs of the Bidāpat Padāvalī.

Amid the present suffering of Maithil migrants, this work is respectfully dedicated to the great poet Vidyāpati.

Is this pain to be found in the Vidyāpati of Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa?

The Padāvalī bears witness to a parallel culture. A single writer could compose in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa at the same time and be distressed when scholars

mocked the use of Avahaṭṭa. But is there even a trace of that distress in the Vidyāpati of the Padāvalī? There we find joy and pain—the joy and pain of the dispossessed. The court-paṇḍit Vidyāpati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa was learned and could be reproached even for composing in Avahaṭṭa. The Maithili Vidyāpati of the parallel tradition remained outside that experience. This parallel tradition reaches back, in the author's argument, to the Ṛgvedic period, with the nārāśaṃsī form. Whether the Vidyāpati within it was from the barber caste or a Brahmin family is not something history conclusively states; yet folklore, his intimate association with the working people who performed Bidāpat, and the local Bisfi tradition are presented here as evidence of his non-Brahmin background. The Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa works never mention the Padāvalī belonging to this poet, nor does that poet's Padāvalī refer to the Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭa works. The Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa texts lament Muslim incursions and the perceived desecration of sacred threads and temples; the Padāvalī instead voices the happiness, sorrow and struggle of common people, without that same outcry. Why, when the poet's very Brahmin identity is in dispute, should putting a pāg on him establish the idea that he was "ours"? Would he cease to be ours if he were not a Brahmin? Would his songs of migration, of the beloved departing for another land, lose their importance? Is the nearly exclusive celebration of his erotic songs itself part of an attempt to limit his legacy? Is it right to bind such a poet within caste identities by crowning him with a pāg? In Madhyakālīn Mithilā, Vijay Kumar Thakur writes that the pervasive feudal religious ideology left enduring traces in Mithila's society and that the pāg itself is associated with Tantric thought (p. 26). Let that headgear, then, remain within the sphere of ritual, marriage and initiation; why draw a poet of the parallel tradition into it? If he belonged to the barber caste, the imposition is unjustified; even if he were a Brahmin, it would remain unjustified, given the hostility to difference still visible among some Brahmins in the twenty-first century. A thousand-year-old poet of a parallel tradition should not be crowned with what the cited historian calls a feudal remnant.

Two Vidyāpatis: Legends and Facts; Bodhi Kāyastha; Uganā Mahādeva

Vidyāpati, the Earliest Poet of Maithili (Before Jyotirīśvara)

Vidyāpati, the Earliest Poet of Maithili (portrait of Vidyāpati by Pankalal Mandal, winner of a Videha painting award)

The earliest poet of Maithili, according to this interpretation, lived before Kaviśvara Jyotirīśvara (approximately 1275–1350), since Jyotirīśvara mentions him in his work. He is distinct from Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa writer. The poet may have been the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur of the barber caste in Bisfi. In the parallel Bidāpat dance tradition, poems of this Vidyāpati's Padāvalī have been sung and enacted since before Jyotirīśvara. The author adduces a mention of Vidyāpati in Abhinavagupta's Īśvarapratyabhijñā-vimarśinī, composed in Kashmir in the late tenth or early eleventh century, as well as five verses cited by Śrīdharadāsa in the Saduktikarṇāmṛta (dated here to 11 February 1206, on the authority of V. K. Thakur's Madhyakālīn Mithilā), in the language of the Padāvalī.

> *"Until the mālatī comes into bloom,*
> *The bee cannot enjoy its honey." And:*
> *"Where is nectar in an unopened bud?"*

Mention is made in Jyotirīśvara (1275–1350), in the sixth kallola, "Description of the Learned" (Atha Vidvanta Varṇanā), and the eighth kallola, "Description of the Kingdom" (Atha Rājya Varṇanā).

In the Bidāpat dance of the parallel tradition, poems from the Padāvalī—understood here to predate Jyotirīśvara—are performed through dance and acting.

Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati (1350–1435), of the Viṣayavāra/Bisfi–Kāśyapa lineage and a courtier of King Śivasiṃha, wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa. His enduring works include the Kīrtilatā, Kīrtipatākā, Puruṣaparīkṣā, Gorakṣavijaya and Likhanāvalī, among many others. This author is distinct from the Vidyāpati whom the present argument identifies as the earliest Maithili poet, before Jyotirīśvara.

Bodhi Kāyastha

The story of Bodhi Kāyastha attaining the Gaṅgā is told in Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati's Puruṣaparīkṣā. A similar story of attaining the Gaṅgā circulated about the great poet Vidyāpati, identified here as the pre-Jyotirīśvara author of the Maithili Padāvalī; subsequently the story became attached to Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati, the writer in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa, as well.

Uganā Mahādeva

Mahādeva, in the form of Uganā, is said to have lived as Vidyāpati's servant so that he could listen to the poet's songs. The tale of Uganā came to be associated with both the earliest Maithili poet Vidyāpati (placed here before Jyotirīśvara) and Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa author at King Śivasiṃha's court.

The Sacred-Thread Ceremony and Installation of the Pāg for Vidyāpati by the Mithila Cultural Council

The Mithila Cultural Council and associates such as Kishorikant Mishra either failed to recognize—or did not wish to recognize—the distinction between Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati of Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa and the Vidyāpati called Kavikokila, the cuckoo among poets. There are written historical records placing Gonu Jha in 1050–1150, yet Usha Kiran Khan has him debate with the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati in her historical Hindi novel Sirjanhār (Bharatiya Jnanpith). Virendra Jha dates Gonu Jha to five hundred years ago and Taranand Viyogi to three hundred years ago, in their respective Hindi books published by Rajkamal Prakashan and the National Book Trust. In Vibha Rani's Hindi book on Gonu Jha (Vani Prakashan), Kunal places him in the reign of Bhava Singh in the fourteenth century. Such disagreement persists even though, the author maintains, the written pañjī registers Gonu Jha ten generations before the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati.

Vidyāpati of the Parallel Tradition and the Pāg. The Sanskrit writings of Vidyāpati Thakur identify a Brahmin author; my concern, however, is with

the Vidyāpati of the Maithili Padāvalī and why he was invested with the pāg and appropriated as "our Vidyāpati." Non-Brahmin communities preserved him for eight hundred years through Bidāpat dance without such a ceremony. The appropriation came after Bengal had claimed the Padāvalī of Vidyāpati and Govindadāsa, and after Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay, in 1875, first identified Vidyāpati as a poet of Mithila, followed by Nagendranath Gupta's identification of Govindadāsa as another poet of Mithila. Bengal resisted these claims before finally accepting them.

The Vidyāpati identified by Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay as belonging to Mithila was the author of the Padāvalī; Bengal had never claimed the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa writer Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati as its own.

The Maithili songs interpolated into Jyotirīśvara's Sanskrit play Dhūrtasamāgama and into the Gorakṣavijaya of the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati testify, in this reading, to an older Padāvalī tradition and demonstrate its influence on both authors.

Scholars of Mithila later brought forward the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa books, along with pañjī entries bearing the names Govindadāsa and Vidyāpati, to produce the identities "Vidyāpati Thakur" and "Govindadāsa Jha" (!!!). Here Ramanath Jha's superficial acquaintance with the pañjī and limited perspective did harm. The author charges that after Indian independence, the Mithila Cultural Council unexpectedly conducted a symbolic investiture with a pāg and proclaimed the Maithili Vidyāpati a Brahmin, thereby converting him into "our Vidyāpati." Numerous poets resembling Jyotirīśvara are also found in the pañjī; why should name discrepancies count in Vidyāpati's case but not in Jyotirīśvara's? Even if this was planned, the author argues, one piece of evidence remained.

Let us turn again to Bidāpat, sung by non-Brahmins and associated, in this argument, with a poet living before Jyotirīśvara, perhaps of the Nāuā Thakur barber caste. Jyotirīśvara is said to mention him in the Varṇaratnākara.

In none of the poems of the Padāvalī does this Vidyāpati describe himself as a Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭa writer. Why does the pain of the dispossessed, so palpable in his songs, not appear in the writings of the other Vidyāpati, whom the author identifies as a Brahmin? The author asserts that the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati expressed disdain for the dispossessed and an explicitly conservative Brahmin identity.

The Padāvalī's Vidyāpati, by contrast, is portrayed as guileless; the author alleges that certain narrowly Brahmanical verses were clumsily inserted by orthodox editors.

The idea of Piyā Desāntar—Vidyāpati's bidesiyā—is now before discerning readers and audiences. In the midst of the present distress of Maithil migrants, it is offered as a tribute to the great poet. Does the Vidyāpati of Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa express this same pain?

The Padāvalī represents a parallel culture. A scholar composing in both Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa might experience derision for writing in the latter language, but that anxiety does not define the Vidyāpati of the Padāvalī. The Padāvalī speaks instead of the joys and sorrows of working people. The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati was a learned court-paṇḍit; even the use of Avahaṭṭa exposed him to criticism. The Maithili Vidyāpati belonged to a different, parallel tradition, traced here back to the Ṛgvedic nārāśaṃsī. Whether that poet belonged to the Nāuā Thakur caste or to a Brahmin family is a question on which historical evidence, in the author's own words, remains silent.

Nevertheless, the author regards the folklore, the close connection of Bidāpat with the labouring poor, and local Bisfi traditions as evidence that the Padāvalī poet was not a Brahmin. The Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa literature does not refer to that Vidyāpati's Padāvalī, nor does the Padāvalī mention those Sanskrit or Avahaṭṭa compositions. The former texts lament Muslim incursions and damage to sacred-thread and temple customs; the latter celebrates common people's happiness, pain and struggle, without that note of outrage. The author adds that Muslims may scarcely have been present in Mithila in the earlier poet's supposed lifetime. When his caste itself is uncertain, what claim is created by placing a pāg on his head? Would he not belong to Mithila if he were not a Brahmin? Would his migration songs lose their significance? Is the tendency to discuss only his erotic lyrics a deliberate distortion? And is it appropriate to constrain a poet within caste boundaries by crowning him with a pāg? Vijay Kumar Thakur, in Madhyakālīn Mithilā, describes the pervasive influence of feudal-era religious ideology and identifies the pāg among the surviving practices associated with Tantric thought (p. 26).

Then let the pāg remain part of ritual, marriage and initiation. Why force it upon Vidyāpati of the parallel tradition? The author assigns responsibility for this act to Kishorikant Mishra's Mithila Cultural Council. If the language and culture have survived despite the conduct of such self-appointed guardians, that survival itself testifies to their strength.

In the Chetana Samiti's magazine, Maneshwar Manuj stated, in a public forum, that Jagadish Prasad Mandal had written only four novels!!!

Had Jagadish Prasad Mandal not carried the surname Mandal, but been known simply as Jagadish Prasad, followers of Ramanath Jha would have declared him a Śrotriya; followers of Amar and Ramdev Jha would have called him a Brahmin, and the author Verma in the Laldas memorial volume would have pronounced him a Kāyastha.

And if no photograph of Jagadish Prasad Mandal had survived, the author argues satirically, Kishorikant Mishra's reactionary Mithila Cultural Council might have performed his sacred-thread ceremony, crowned him with a pāg, and repeated a thousand years later the injustice allegedly committed against Vidyāpati. Some elderly villager of Berma might then have pointed to a

mound of earth and called it the imaginary ancestral homestead of "Jagadish Prasad Jha/Thakur."

Videha has also published, without cutting, abusive responses from Malangiya's son, Ramdev Jha's son and numerous pseudonymous writers so that readers may judge them; only abuse that could not be printed was withheld. Fear of such attacks, the author claims, led historians of Maithili and Mithila to hint at this issue without pursuing it further.

Thus the argument returns to the conclusion that this Vidyāpati preceded Jyotirīśvara (1275–1350). The song-and-dance world of Jayadeva (c. 1200) and the kīrtaniyā tradition, the author argues, accord with the Padāvalī of the pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati, not with the literary refinement of the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati.

Let us return, then, to the platform of the Mithila Cultural Council. In the author's formulation, the Council did not conduct the sacred-thread ceremony of Vidyāpati alone; it conducted a sacred-thread ceremony for Maithili itself. The pāg placed on its Vidyāpati erased Bindhyeshwar Mandal and Shrikant Mandal of Kolkata from the picture, completing the symbolic initiation of Maithili into that restricted identity.

Consider examples of the caste orthodoxy of the Vidyāpati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa:

Kīrtilatā: "Marriage across caste boundaries carries one to degradation."

In the course of narrating a story in the Puruṣaparīkṣā, Vidyāpati offers an authorial statement that Rajput women are of loose character. The author compares this with a supposed statement that a Śūdra's wife could be taken away by holding her hand without consent, then immediately insists that no such statement ever occurs in the Atharvaveda—or, indeed, in any Veda.

Śukla Yajurveda 26.2: "Yathemāṃ vācaṃ kalyāṇīm āvadāni janebhyaḥ; brahmarājanyābhyāṃ śūdrāya cāryāya ca svāya cāraṇāya ca." Let us make this auspicious, sacred speech—the words of the Veda—heard by all: Brahmins, Kṣatriyas, Śūdras and Āryas, our own people and strangers alike, that is, everyone. The author argues that the Manusmṛti, contrary to this Vedic declaration, tried to prohibit the study or hearing of Vedic words to certain sections of society. Yet even the Smṛti acknowledges Vedic speech as authoritative testimony (śabda-pramāṇa), so its contrary injunction, he argues, invalidates itself.

But such a claim is indeed present in the Puruṣaparīkṣā. Do you believe the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati would have possessed the courage to write in this manner about women of his patron's caste?

The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati repeatedly emphasizes caste distinctions; purity of blood and caste, the author argues, are important to him. He is represented as claiming that a person of low birth deserves no compassion,

that beauty is the monopoly of the wealthy and privileged, that caste is the final determinant of social existence, and that someone born in an inferior family can only be a snake with an evil mind. The same Vidyāpati—the one invested with sacred thread and pāg by Kishorikant Mishra's Mithila Cultural Council—is cited as calling a country without caste rules a mleccha country. The discussion refers to Upendra Thakur's Aspects of Society and Economy of Medieval Mithila.

I have not encountered a description of the pāg earlier than Amīr Khusro.

> *By contrast, the pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati, author of the Padāvalī, says:*
> *"Here the king punishes no one."*
> *"All the great men are of our own kind."*

Thus, the king gives no punishment to anyone, and all the eminent people are of a common kind.

Govindadāsa's verses were difficult, and no comparable parallel tradition sustained them—perhaps, the author suggests, because they circulated mainly among upper-caste groups. They were therefore not preserved in the soil of Mithila as Bidāpat dance was. Consider also Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi. Vardhamāna calls him sukavi-kairava-kānana-indu, the moon illuminating a forest of poetic water-lilies; where have those poems gone? Pakṣadhara forbade the copying of texts, but Raghunātha Śiromaṇi and his disciples memorized the works of Udayana and Gaṅgeśa and carried that learning away. With the foundation of the Navya-Nyāya school at Navadvīpa, students ceased coming from Bengal to Mithila.

Regarding the pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati, the author invokes Abhinavagupta of Kashmir (late tenth to early eleventh century) and a mention of Vidyāpati in the Īśvarapratyabhijñā-vimarśinī.

Śrīdharadāsa's Saduktikarṇāmṛta quotes five verses attributed to Vidyāpati, in the language of the Padāvalī.

> *"Until the mālatī blossoms,*
> *The bee has no delight in it."*
> *And:*
> *"Where is nectar in the unopened bud?"*

(Vijay Kumar Thakur, Madhyakālīn Mithilā.)

Jyotirīśvara (1275–1350), sixth kallola, "Description of the Learned" (Atha Vidvanta Varṇanā). The archaic reading is transcribed in full below, followed by the explanation that the text itself supplies:

jyotirīśvara (1275-1350) ṣaṣṭhaḥ kallola- ॥latha vidyāvanta varṇanā ॥….. vidātaño āsthāna bhītara bhau. takā pachā telaṅgī. marahaṭhī. vi. daotinī dui citrakai gāṅga jauna nihāli aisani deṣuaha. cauāñcari cīri ekahoṅka parihane .....se kaisana deṣu. jaise prayāgakṣetra sarasvatīkē gaṅgājamunāka samvāhi. kā ho taise tā vidāñotake duao samvāhikā ho bhauaha. daśañundhī rājā avadhāna

karāu. vidāñota āsthāna vaisu.
In English: the vidāot enters the assembly; behind him come Telugu and Maratha performers. Two vidāotinīs appear, wearing garments with four ends, their two-coloured figures likened to the Gaṅgā and Yamunā mingling with Sarasvatī at Prayāga. King Daśaundhī is called to attention, and the vidāot is invited to sit. The following paragraph preserves the author's own gloss.

(The vidāot, a male performer, entered, followed by Telugu and Maratha performers. The two vidāotinīs, or women performers, seemed to have bathed in the two-coloured streams of the Gaṅgā and Yamunā. Each wore a garment with four ends. Picture them as the Sarasvatī joined by the Gaṅgā and Yamunā at Prayāga: the vidāot appeared accompanied by these two female attendants. King Daśaundhī was called to attention, and the vidāot sat in his place.)

Eighth kallola, "Description of the Kingdom" (Atha Rājya Varṇanā): "... the songs of the vidāot, their dance, instruments and rhythms; they came wearing skirts ..."

The vidāot performers sang, danced and played musical instruments and rhythms, wearing skirts.

Uganā Mahādeva: Mahādeva, assuming the form of Uganā, is said to have become Vidyāpati's servant to hear his songs. The legend became attached both to the earliest Maithili Vidyāpati, placed here before Jyotirīśvara, and to Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati, the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa author at King Śivasiṃha's court.

Bodhi Kāyastha: The story of his attainment of the Gaṅgā occurs in Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati's Puruṣaparīkṣā. The same story was once associated with the great poet Vidyāpati, held here to have composed the pre-Jyotirīśvara Maithili Padāvalī; later it was also attached to Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati, author of Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa works.

Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati's Sanskrit literature emerged in a period when Mithila's learned tradition was declining. The author finds little distinctive discussion of Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati in Sanskrit literary history; the arrival of students from Bengal was also diminishing. For those who still visited, his Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa books were contemporary works from a fading scholarly environment and were still being composed. By contrast, the earlier Padāvalī had already achieved fame. It is not even certain that the pāg existed in Mithila during Gonu Jha's or the earlier Vidyāpati's lifetime: the author cites Amīr Khusro (1253–1325) as its first known witness. Vijay Kumar Thakur interprets it as a feudal emblem associated with Tantric ritual. The author speculates that subordinate feudal chiefs were given the headgear after Muslim incursions and notes its similarity to Muslim caps. He further states that Brahmins and Kāyasthas, rather than Rajputs, were the subordinate feudal elites in Mithila at that time and that the pāg still sometimes appears at marriages and related ceremonies among those two groups.

Mahākavi Vidyāpati: The earliest poet of Maithili, according to this argument, predates Kaviśvara Jyotirīśvara (c. 1275–1350), who refers to him, and is distinct from the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa author Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati. By local tradition he may have been the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur, a Nāuā Thakur barber of Bisfi village. The parallel Bidāpat dance tradition has enacted his Padāvalī, held here to predate Jyotirīśvara.

Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati (1350–1435), of the Viṣayavāra/Bisfi–Kāśyapa lineage, was a courtier of King Śivasiṃha and a writer in Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa. He produced many lasting works, including Kīrtilatā, Kīrtipatākā, Puruṣaparīkṣā, Gorakṣavijaya and Likhanāvalī. The author distinguishes him from the earliest Maithili poet Vidyāpati, whom he places before Jyotirīśvara.

Phanishwarnath Renu wrote a reportage on Bidāpat dance, published in the weekly Viśvamitra on 1 August 1945. Its importance, the author argues, lies in the fact that it appeared about seven hundred years after Jyotirīśvara described this tradition. Throughout those intervening centuries a parallel community kept Vidyāpati alive; then, he charges, the poet was suddenly taken away from those who had preserved him. Bindeshwar Thakur died singing Vidyāpati's songs and lamenting that Brahmins had appropriated the poet by crowning him with the pāg. Kanungo Badri Prasad Thakur of Brahmpura, Binod Thakur of Pokharbhira, Saryug Thakur of Rudrapur, Jairam Thakur of Mehath, and the whole village of Bisfi are said still to repeat this grievance. Shaligram Yadav and Awadhiya Thakur are offered as witnesses to the Bisfi tradition. All manner of fanciful arguments have been advanced concerning Vidyāpati's birth in the course of what the author calls a ritual appropriation, yet research papers have failed even to mention the parallel tradition. This essay is dedicated to the thousands of people like Bindeshwar Thakur who kept Vidyāpati alive between the descriptions of Jyotirīśvara and Phanishwarnath Renu.

The Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa tradition of Mithila and the region's parallel tradition. Language may have existed before the Ṛgveda, the earliest surviving work of Vedic Sanskrit. Oral forms such as gāthā, nārāśaṃsī, narratives of the gods and other tales may already have been composed in it. The Ṛgveda uses terms such as gāthin, gātuvit and gāthapati for singers of such compositions. Gāthā and nārāśaṃsī existed beside the formal Vedic tradition. Did Vedic Sanskrit arise out of Prakrit, or Prakrit out of Vedic Sanskrit? The narratives of people called nārāśaṃsī in the Vedas, the author argues, indicate that the two traditions coexisted for a long period and influenced one another. Consider the Ṛgvedic use of dūlabha for durlabha (Ṛgveda 4.9.8), the Atharvavedic paścā for paścāt (Atharvaveda 10.4.10), or pratisahāya for pratisandhāya in the Gopatha Brāhmaṇa (2.4). What do these forms establish? The Āryas, according to the author's historical reconstruction, came to Mithila from western India, while parts of the Vedas already existed before their arrival. This, he contends, accounts for words and pronunciations found in modern Maithili and in Vedic—but not classical—Sanskrit. Avidyā, the law of karma,

cycles of birth and rebirth, and liberation are also described here as ideas received by the Āryas from non-Āryan traditions. Accordingly, the Upaniṣads teach the way to liberation rather than merely the way to heaven. Can liberation be gained by sacrifice? No: it comes through knowledge, reflection, contemplation and samādhi. Under King Janaka's patronage, Yājñavalkya composed the Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad in the non-Āryan Tirhut region. Explaining the fifty-seventh sūtra of the Sāṃkhyakārikā, Vācaspati Miśra asks whether one may argue that just as unconscious milk nourishes a calf, unconscious prakṛti can bring living beings toward liberating knowledge. God is complete in himself: to what end would he create the universe? If for the sake of living beings, those beings become bound only after creation; before creation there can be no bondage and hence no occasion for divine pity. Creation, then, comes through prakṛti, and living beings attain apavarga by their own effort. The author reads this explanation of dissolution through discernment as atheistic rather than theistic. If God intervened in the operation of prakṛti, that conscious intervention would have a purpose, but God has no unmet purpose. Gautama of Mithila, author of the Nyāyasūtras, discusses attaining niḥśreyasa through knowledge of sixteen categories, without attributing liberation there to God. The Vaiśeṣika-sūtra, on this account, considers the Vedas the work of learned people, not divine authorship. Kumārila Bhaṭṭa holds that reliable discussion of God before creation is impossible. Thus the so-called mainstream Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa tradition had a parallel stream from the outset: Brahminical and non-Brahminical ways existed together in Mithila. Jyotirīśvara remarks that the Buddhist side appears terrifying. An unchanging Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa-oriented movement, the author argues, is occupied with sanctifying the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati because of a common name. Ṛgvedic and nārāśaṃsī traditions, the great poet Vidyāpati and the pāg-invested Vidyāpati, liberation and heaven-or-hell: these conflicting positions have long coexisted in Mithila. In one account, Vidhegha Māthava of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa and Nimi of the Purāṇas share the priest Gautama, and this marks the beginning of the Videha kingdom. Gautama, the priest of Māthava, inaugurated the Mitravinda rite and sacrifice; Yājñavalkya restored it in the reign of Mahājanaka II. The tradition that endlessly invoked Maitreyī, Yājñavalkya, Sītā and Janaka could swiftly perform Vidyāpati's sacred-thread ceremony and pāg investiture precisely because such acts fitted its version of the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa mainstream. After Madhava Singh ordered the compilation of the śākhā-pañjī in 1760, the author says, new forms of elite lineage classification spread among Brahmins and Kāyasthas, creating the Battiśgāmiyā/Bhalmānus sub-group among Karṇa Kāyasthas and the Śrotriya sub-group among Maithil Brahmins. He associates those developments with rising hereditary physical and mental illness and with increased polygamy, child marriage and widowhood in both communities, again attributing the apparently smooth and rapid transition to the dominance of this supposed mainstream.

Dineshwar Lal Anand and Ramvriksha Benipuri on Vidyāpati. Dineshwar Lal Anand, the author argues, was mistaken because the pañjī was still secret at the time. The registers placed the Viṣayavāra/Bisfi lineage of the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati in the lower Jayavāra category. The śākhā-pañjī did not exist before 1760, he argues, as shown by the descendants of Ayachi Mishra: the lower generations of that mūla appear both under the Śrotriya sub-caste and within the wider Brahmin classification. He compares this to depictions of bulls but no cows on Indus Valley seals: how could bulls exist without cows? Anand did not possess the entire pañjī record. Perhaps, in trying to show that the Padāvalī Vidyāpati and the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati were identical, he thought that connecting the Bisfi lineage's alleged demotion with the latter's writing in Avahaṭṭa would make Ṭhakkura Vidyāpati appear a revolutionary. Yet Anand acknowledges that no song anthology survives either in Vidyāpati's own handwriting or with a documented compilation from his lifetime. How can that be, the author asks, when the Sanskrit and Avahaṭṭa works announce their beginnings and endings, record which kings and queens inspired them, and identify their patrons with full authorial flourish and the blessings of Sarasvatī and Lakṣmī? Why is there no such apparatus around the Padāvalī? Anand, he says, has no answer. The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa author names his patrons but says little about himself. He even feels pressure when writing in Avahaṭṭa, then a principal literary language of that establishment. The earlier Padāvalī poet's influence was so powerful that the later author had to include Maithili songs in the Sanskrit play Gorakṣavijaya—just as Jyotirīśvara, who first recorded the vidāot performance, included Maithili songs in his Sanskrit Dhūrtasamāgama. Govind Jha sees and discusses the earlier Vidyāpati tradition in Jyotirīśvara's vidāot, yet, the author asks, why does he fail to follow it when Bindeshwar Thakur dies singing its songs? How does the village in which a play about Vidyāpati locates the poet's thirst suddenly become the playwright's own village? Everyone, he says, writes a play about "our Vidyāpati" according to personal convenience. Ramvriksha Benipuri too lacked the pañjī evidence. On the basis of a newly constructed sub-caste and a legend, he writes dismissively of Keshav Mishra's Vidyāpati; the Keshav Mishra in the Dvaita appendix was a grandson of Vācaspati II (1400–1490). Another Keshav Mishra (c. 1150) wrote the Tarkabhāṣā, later criticized in the Tarkaprakāśa by Vardhamāna, son of Gaṅgeśa, the author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. Benipuri did not advance even one step beyond Ananda Coomaraswamy's research of 1915, the author contends, nor has another mainstream scholar advanced beyond it in the succeeding century. Benipuri repeats the Uganā legend but remains silent on whether Mahādeva would dance on Kailāsa to the Śaivasarvasvasāra of the orthodox Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati or to the nācārī songs of the pre-Jyotirīśvara poet. Like Coomaraswamy, Benipuri knew of a Bhāgavata manuscript in the handwriting of the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati and of the story in which the Gaṅgā supposedly engulfed the poet. He had heard of that writer's Puruṣaparīkṣā, but, the author insists, had not read it: otherwise he would have known that the book tells the Gaṅgā-attainment story about Bodhi Kāyastha.

That story, like the Uganā legend, was associated with the earlier Vidyāpati before being attached to the other poet through ritual reinterpretation; the Bodhi Kāyastha episode is offered as evidence. Benipuri even describes the Kīrtipatākā as a collection of Maithili songs!! Is this how research is conducted, by hearsay? Why has the supposedly dry mainstream not moved beyond the foundations laid by Coomaraswamy a century ago? Because, the author answers, the Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa-oriented mainstream will not allow it. Meanwhile, without evidence, Benipuri pronounces King Śivasiṃha's friend Purāditya a Bhūmihār Brahmin—just as Ramanath Jha calls Govindadāsa (Jha) a Śrotriya, a classification Sukumar Sen considered absurd; Ramdev Jha also makes him a Brahmin, and a writer named Verma, in the Laldas memorial volume, makes Kālidāsa a Kāyastha. The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati begins and ends his books with ritual observances and acknowledges his royal patrons, but not himself. Why, then, did the Padāvalī persist in living voices without the formal apparatus of books? Because, the author concludes, those songs were composed centuries before the court author and before the pāg emerged in Mithila. Names such as Rūpanārāyaṇa, Śivasiṃha, Lakhimā, Devasiṃha, Harasiṃha, Padmasiṃha, Viśvāsadeva, Arjuna, Amara, Rāghavasiṃha, Rudrasiṃha, Dhīrasiṃha, Bhairavasiṃha and Candrasiṃha were later inserted into the Padāvalī, he alleges, often disrupting the metre. The Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa author's works, by contrast, were openly commissioned or patron-supported: Bhūparikramā for Devasiṃha; Kīrtilatā for Kīrtisiṃha and Vīrasiṃha; Kīrtipatākā; Gorakṣavijaya for Śivasiṃha; Likhanāvalī for Purāditya; and Dānavākyāvalī for Queen Dhīramatī. Gorakṣavijaya was composed for a Bhairava worship ceremony and included Maithili songs, like the earlier Dhūrtasamāgama, reflecting the great influence of the earlier poet. Had the names not differed, the author concludes provocatively, Jyotirīśvara himself might have been turned into the "pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati."

Conclusion. Gaṅgeśa, author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, wrote a work said to equal twelve thousand books in extent. Professor Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila: "The family which was inferior in social status is now extinct in Mithila...Gangesha's family is completely ignored and we are not expected to know even his father's name." The author notes that Bhattacharya attributes this information to Professor R. Jha (Ramanath Jha). Yet, according to the author, the pañjī expressly states that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death and married a woman of the leather-working caste. Why, then, did Ramanath Jha conceal these matters from Bhattacharya? The author alleges that an elite sub-caste promoted a tale of Gaṅgeśa's transformation from fool to scholar and sought to erase his family. Gaṅgeśa's son Vardhamāna calls him sukavi-kairava-kānana-indu, the moon of a grove of poetic lilies; where have the poems of so famous a scholar disappeared, and through what process? Vāsudeva of Bengal studied in Mithila alongside Pakṣadhara Miśra, passed the śalākā examination and gained the title Sārvabhauma. He memorized the kārikās of Gaṅgeśa's

Tattvacintāmaṇi and Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali. The teachers of Mithila, including Pakṣadhara, forbade students to copy the Tattvacintāmaṇi. Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, a disciple of Vāsudeva, defeated his teacher Pakṣadhara Miśra in debate and gained the right to publish or disseminate the text. Vāsudeva and Raghunātha established the Navya-Nyāya school in Navadvīpa. Pakṣadhara was contemporary with the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati, and students from Bengal then stopped coming to Mithila. Grierson called the Bisfi copperplate granted by Śivasiṃha to the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati a forgery: being familiar with the Padāvalī, he could not imagine its Vidyāpati receiving such a grant. He did not recognize the distinction between the two poets. Mahāmahopādhyāya Haraprasad Shastri, however, did distinguish them and declared the copperplate genuine. Śrīdharadāsa's Saduktikarṇāmṛta contains a Kaivarta poet Papīhā's hymn to the Gaṅgā and songs of Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa. Dhoyī, court poet of Lakṣmaṇasena, belonged to the Jolhā weaving community, according to the account.

Lakhimā Ṭhākurāin wrote verse in Sanskrit, not the Padāvalī (Grierson). Śrīdharadāsa's inscription is at Andhrāṭhāṛhī; he served as a minister to Nānyadeva and Gaṅgadeva. His descendant Amiakar was contemporary with the Sanskrit-and-Avahaṭṭa Vidyāpati. Upendra Thakur treats Gaṅgadeva as a Kalacuri ruler; Vijay Kumar Thakur interprets the Vidyāpati songs in Śrīdharadāsa's Saduktikarṇāmṛta as praising the Kalacuri Karṇa. Radhakrishna Chaudhary holds a different view.

Under any interpretation, the author concludes, this Vidyāpati preceded Jyotirīśvara.

Rāmacarita: Vigrahapāla III defeated Karṇa. Radhakrishna Chaudhary found two Pāla inscriptions at Naulagarh, sixteen kilometres north of Begusarai, relevant to this conflict. That Karṇa also belongs to the eleventh century.

The poems of the pre-Jyotirīśvara Vidyāpati were known in Bengal, while Jyotirīśvara's Dhūrtasamāgama was known in southern India. Later the flow of students from Bengal to Mithila ceased, as did the outward circulation of Mithila's drama and Padāvalī.

Appendices

Appendix 1

Phanishwarnath Renu: Vidyāpati in a Folk-Song Tradition

While researching the great poet Vidyāpati, I began to think that a chapter would have to be called "Vidyāpati, Poet of Cultivators, Labourers and Cart-Drivers." For even today, in the Purnia–Saharsa region, groups perform the songs of Vidyāpati's Padāvalī with expressive dance. The leaders of these troupes are often buffalo-riders, herdsmen and drivers of bullock carts. I asked some Maithil paṇḍits:

"How did this happen?" They replied, "What are you getting yourself into? It is because of such fools that Vidyāpati has fallen into his present state. These ordinary people took it into their heads to put together 'four Padāvalī verses' in his name. You are being misled." Ignoring the prohibition pronounced by the scholars, I gladly began planning a journey to Saharsa (or Sahrasa?). Kanchira is a village ruled by the district magistrates of two districts: half lies in Saharsa and half in Purnia. The Vidyāpati troupe of Kanchira is spoken of in both districts. On the day I arrived, an extraordinary event had just occurred: the political leader who had represented the area for ten years had been decisively defeated at the polls. A performance that night might have been read as a political demonstration. Fearing this, Janakdas, leader of the Vidyāpati troupe, refused permission for a dance. Only after much persuasion did he agree to a performance the following night. After prolonged and circuitous argument, Janakdas declared that Vidyāpati dance had originated in his own family, but he would never give particulars. When he finally believed that I was not an agent seeking to draw a thousand or two thousand rupees from the government treasury in the name of a Vidyāpati dance troupe, he struck the mṛdaṅga. I watched the dance all night. A cowherd boy in a sari became the grief-stricken Rādhā and sang through tears, "How many days will Hari keep you waiting, you lonely woman?" Next day I asked Janakdas about the dance's origins. He answered that for as long as anyone remembered, its hereditary singing had continued in the family, though he could not say from when. His reserve was caused by my tape recorder: "You have cleverly recorded all our songs on tape in secret. You have got your work done for nothing, haven't you?" Even after I paid him fifty rupees, he would not answer when and how farmers, labourers, cowherds and cart-drivers first began to sing and dance the Padāvalī. I lay all day on straw in his hut; he felt no pity. Even his young widowed daughter pleaded for me, but he remained unmoved: would I have his family's reputation made a laughingstock by having it printed in the "gazette"? Old Janakdas went off to unyoke and graze his oxen. Still lying in his hut, I then heard a story, or had a dream, or fell under an illusion—I cannot say which.

Appendix 2

Bidāpat Dance (Original Reportage by Phanishwarnath Renu)

Bidāpat Dance

This dance is believed to have originated in Darbhanga district. What condition it now occupies in its own homeland scarcely needs saying. Yet it is still cherished in villages of certain districts of northern Bihar, and in Bhagalpur, Purnia and elsewhere. It has come to be regarded as a dance of the lower people. Members of the so-called respectable classes consider it beneath them even to watch. Among Musahars, Dhāṅgaṛs and Dusādhs, however, it flourishes at weddings, tonsure ceremonies and other celebrations. The troupe has seven or eight performers and only two instruments, the mṛdaṅga drum

and the mañjīrā cymbals. Come, then, let us enjoy Bidāpat dance. For a little while, set aside our supposed respectability …

"Dhṛṅg dhā, dhṛṅg dhā, tinnā"—the mṛdaṅga thundered into speech. "Kun kun kun kun …"—the cymbals joined its voice.

"Gaṇanāyakaṃ phaladāyakaṃ paṇḍitam patitam …" Please do not laugh. That was the auspicious invocation, in pure Sanskrit.

"Dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā"—the mṛdaṅga began to play.

"Kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ …"—the cymbals accompanied it.

The dancers began circling in every direction around the people assembled there. Behind them Bipṭā too spun like a top, contorting his face in all manner of expressions and crying, "Oy, oy, oy, oy!" The mṛdaṅga changed its rhythm: "Dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī, dhirināṅgī." The cymbals answered: "Kinkāṃ, kinkāṃ …" Enough; we have danced enough. We shall come to the tale of the dance later.

The performers gathered at one place and began swaying. "Dhirināṅgi tintā, tiṭak-tiṭak dhā, tiṭakal gadagin dhā."

The rhythm ended; the dance too was over, and the dancers pulled their veils over their faces and sat among the spectators. Bipṭā, the clown of the performance, began looking for them. "Dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā …"

"Dhin-tinak tinak, dhin tinak-tinak"—the drum sounded.

The chorus joined in tune.

"Here enters the supremely delicate maiden,
Swan-gaited, the beloved daughter of Vṛṣabhānu …"

The dancers rose and came up to Bipṭā. Overjoyed, he began crying, "Oy, oy, oy, oy!"

"Dhin-tinak tinak, dhin-tinak tinak."

"Ah! Her body, mind and face are naturally graceful,
The moon has risen above the lightning …"

The dancers lifted their veils. The spectators roared with laughter at the moonlike faces—ill-shaven beards and moustaches, awkward features and all. The dancer, eyes lowered, performed while shrinking with bashfulness like a touch-me-not plant. Bipṭā tried to attract the dancer's attention.

"Ah! The auspicious bride smiles on seeing her beloved,
Then turns away her face in modesty …"

The dancer smiled and turned away, displaying teeth blackened by chewing tobacco. Please be quiet, all of you. Yes, yes, certainly: it may be Vidyāpati's Padāvalī, but what you are seeing is Bidāpat dance.

New Theatres, Vidyāpati, Kanan Bala—go and stop Pahari Sanyal's endless chatter. I have begun the last melodic phrase.

How often must I explain that this is Bidāpat dance, and that the performer is Ṭahlu Paswan? His father was a notorious bandit, sentenced to transportation across the black waters. His mother went away with another man; he began dancing as a child. In his youth he caused a sensation, a tremendous sensation. Parbatiya, entranced by his gestures, abandoned an established household and ran away with him in the middle of the night.

Yes, Ṭahlu Paswan can sing:

"When my playful beloved comes into the courtyard,
I shall turn back with the faintest smile;
Kānhā will try so many ways ..."

"Dhṛnnā dhṛṅgā, tinā-tinnā"—the mṛdaṅga shifted to another rhythm.

"Kinnā, kinnā"—the cymbals too changed their beat.

"O friend ...
O friend, why ask me of my experience?"
"All my life I have looked upon that beauty,
Yet I have never been satisfied."

"Hey! Quiet! Quiet!" Bipṭā shouted angrily. One of the chorus members began twisting a towel into a whip. Bipṭā protested that beating him only wasted time. His back, he said, had been toughened by the landlord's shoes. He had silenced them for one reason only ...

"Whose beauty had that person looked upon all his life?" When Bipṭā understood that it was his own, he brightened, instantly drew a little mirror from his pocket and proudly admired his face.

The song finished. Now it was time for Bipṭā Mahādeva.

"Listen, leader!"
"Hmm?"
"Now hear my song too."
"Oh, father!
Oh, what misery have I not endured!
For seven years I paid the interest,
Yet I was never free of debt.
I worked day and night like an oil-press ox,
But the burden only grew.
I sold my plate to pay the land-records clerk,
My drinking vessel to pay the village watchman.
I sold my goat to pay the constable;
Now I am the penniless Giridhari."

Do you understand anything? You too are all penniless Giridharis, every last one of you.

Just look at the spectators: what have they understood that their stomachs hurt from laughing so hard?

"Dhṛṅgā, dhṛṅgā, dhidhinnā tinnā ..."

"O friend!
It is the month of Bhādra, the clouds are full,
And my house stands empty ..."

Beautiful! Beautiful! Indeed, Vidyāpati is the cuckoo of Mithila ...

You are drifting away again. You are no better than Bipṭā: however much one restrains you, you insist on interpreting every song. And here, look, Bipṭā himself has returned.

"This month of Bhādra, rain clouds pour,
And water leaks through my thatched roof!"

"Ha, ha, ha!" The audience rolled about with laughter. I forgot to mention that Bipṭā thinks of himself as Kṛṣṇa, and also as a lover travelling abroad; yet he never forgets that he is Kalaru Musahar from Halhaliya and, though human, has a standing no higher than an ox at the oil press. When the dancers link their arms around his neck and act out the pride and reproach of love—"Mādhava, why have you abandoned us and gone abroad?"—he forgets that he is Kṛṣṇa leaving Gokul for Mathura. The inequalities of his own life then rise before him like living figures and he sings:

"The Ādrā rain has failed, and so has the Aśleṣā rain;
On all sides we see nothing but the grey hair of old women ...
The fish and turtles have gone down to the underworld;
Will a terrible famine come now, my friend?
A whole day's labour brings a single seer of grain;
How shall we keep ourselves alive on that?
Farewell, my love, I am going to another land."

But the very next moment the dancer sings:

"I took my sweetheart on my lap and went to market;
The people at the stalls asked, 'What relation is he to you?'
'My mother-in-law's boy, my sister-in-law's elder brother;
The husband written for me by fate in a former life.'"

Bipṭā now began whining like a child for jalebis, sweet batāśās and toys.

Just then one of the dancers sang:

"When the night turned towards dawn,
My husband came home.
My hands trembled with excitement; the necklace burned upon my breast;
His lotus hands touched my bosom as I gazed at his moonlike face."

Bipṭā interrupted and asked a chorus member to explain the song. The singer began expounding it openly: how the heroine had been sleeping on straw in her hut when Bipṭā arrived. Let us look among the spectators. Dark, robust young women suppressed smiles, nudged one another, whispered with delight and stared straight at Bipṭā. Middle-aged women pretended to be angry and tried to restrain the girls; but how can suppressed laughter and a heart stirred with amusement ever be controlled?

Meanwhile the dancers burst into a refrain.

"Come, my heart, come, my heart—to my husband's home
We shall go, O Rāma!
For O Rāma, in my parents' house
I shall set a fire ..."

The young women grew restless; an electric current seemed to run through the young men's veins. The performance was nearing its end.

"Come, my heart, come, my heart—
Dhin dhinak dhinak, dhin dhinak dhinak ...
For O Rāma, in my parents' house I shall set a fire ...
Ḍim ḍimik ḍimik, ḍim ḍimik ḍimik ..."

What's this? Why, it is Chethru Gusain! Gusain is a devotee of Kabir. Ten or fifteen years ago he refused to give false testimony at the landlord's request. Enraged, the landlord drove him from his home, and since then he has lived as a renunciant. A khañjarī tambourine, a shoulder bag and tongs, matted hair and a long beard—look! Gusain has begun playing the khañjarī and dancing alongside the performers.

"Ḍim ḍimik ḍimik, ḍim ḍimik ḍimik,
For O Rāma, in my parents' house I shall set a fire ..."

The point is that Chethru Gusain takes this song to be entirely nirguṇa—devotion to the formless absolute.

Ah! Tears gleam in his sunken eyes. And the dance comes to an end.

(This reportage by Phanishwarnath Renu appeared in the weekly Viśvāmitra on 1 August 1945. This Maithili translation from Hindi, by Madhupnath Jha, published in Videha: Sadeha II, is dedicated to Phanishwarnath Renu.)

Appendix 3

Vidyāpati's Bidesiyā: Piyā Desāntar—A Parallel World of Maithili Theatre Beyond Bidāpat Dance

Rāmkhelāvan Maṇḍal came from the village of Kaṭghaṭrā, Shivājīnagar block, Samastipur district; Bindeśvar Maṇḍal accompanied him. People still remember the rising Maithili chorus and the song, "Mother, O mother, get me a gun, for I, mother, shall become a soldier!" This troupe staged verse-dramas such as Reshmā–Chūhaṛ, Sīt–Basant, Alhā–Ūdal and Naṭuā Dayāl.

The Piyā Desāntar (Maithili Bidesiyā) company came from Purnia to Supaul, Saharsa, Samastipur and other places. The dramatic piece Hasan–Husan was performed. The Rāmrakṣā Chaudhary Nāṭyakalā Pariṣad, village Gāyghāṭ, Kariyan panchayat, post office Vaidyānāthpur, Samastipur district, staged Vidyāpati as far afield as Gorakhpur. Its other productions included Lauṅgiyā Merachāi, Vidyāpati, Chīnīk Laḍḍū and Basāt.

It is on this basis that the following dramatic conception is presented.

Vidyāpati's Piyā Desāntar (My Beloved in a Distant Land)

Scene 1

Onstage, the bidesiyā—the man departing for a distant country—takes his leave to seek employment, while the young woman sings. A traveller enters during the song. At the other end of the stage, thieves crouch in hiding. At yet another edge, the constable and a man in a spotless white dhoti sit carefree, their hands resting on their bellies.

In the Dhanachī rāga (from the Vidyāpati Padāvalī preserved in Nepal):

> *"I am a young woman; my husband has gone abroad. Not even the faintest presence of a neighbour remains nearby."*

I am young, and my husband has gone to a distant land. There is not so much as a trace of a neighbour close at hand.

> *"Mother-in-law and sister-in-law know nothing at all; their eyes are night-blind, their ears cannot hear."*

Neither my mother-in-law nor my sister-in-law understands anything. Their eyes suffer from night-blindness, and they cannot hear with their ears either.

> *"Stay awake, traveller; do not go before dawn. The night is dark and the village is full of thieves."*

O traveller, shake off sleep. Do not come—or venture forth—before morning. It is a dark night, and there are many thieves in the village.

> *"The constable keeps no watch, not even in dreams; even when approached, he will not give the matter thought."*

The constable does not stand guard even in his dreams; not even an invitation or appeal moves him to consider the matter.

> *"Here the king brings no one peace."*

"The men of standing and authority are all of my own community."
"So sings the poet Vidyāpati of this sentiment; through suggestive utterance he discloses its meaning."

The poet Vidyāpati sings of this emotional state, conveying its import through his poetic expression.

The poet Vidyāpati enters. A man in a clean white dhoti and a poor man approach the constable. Judging by outward appearance alone, the constable decides in favour of the white-clad man. At the other corner of the stage, the young woman beats her forehead in anguish. Vidyāpati himself sings the last four lines of the song.

Scene 2

The young woman symbolically opens a shop. From the other side of the stage, her mother-in-law and sister-in-law leave, and a traveller arrives as a customer. The young woman begins singing. After every line Vidyāpati enters, explains its meaning, and fades into darkness. In the final line, however, Vidyāpati sings and the young woman speaks its meaning.

In the Mālava rāga (from the Vidyāpati Padāvalī preserved in Nepal):

"How cool the shade of this tree! Here and there, villages have settled."

The shade beneath this tree is exceedingly cool, and villages have sprung up here and there.

"I am alone; my beloved is abroad; nowhere is there any mention of wicked men."

I am by myself, my beloved is in a foreign land, and no wicked person is spoken of anywhere.

"O traveller, come and rest here."

O traveller, take your rest here.

"Whatever you wish to buy is not costly; everything is available in this place."

Whatever you purchase will not be expensive. Everything can be found here.

"My mother-in-law is not at home; my relations are far away; my sister-in-law is innocent by nature."

My mother-in-law is absent from the house, other relatives are far away, and my sister-in-law is simple-hearted by nature.

"Even so, traveller, if you turn away and go, I shall have no power left."

Despite all this, should you turn away and depart, nothing further will be within my power.

"Vidyāpati says: listen, young woman, you who fulfil another's hope."

Vidyāpati says: O young woman, listen—you are one who fulfils the hopes of others.

Scene 3

Vidyāpati does not appear in this song. The young woman sees her sister-in-law pressing the traveller to leave, and remembers her own beloved who has gone to a distant land. Addressing both her sister-in-law and her female friend, she sings. After every line, her friend explains the meaning.

In the Dhanachī rāga (from the Vidyāpati Padāvalī preserved in Nepal):

> *"One living in a foreign land depends on others' kindness. Turn no one away; offer shelter without fail."*

In a strange land a person must continually depend upon other people. Therefore no one should be turned away; a place to stay must certainly be offered.

> *"Here, friend, understand this much of the beloved's story."*

O friend, understand at least this much about the condition of my beloved.

> *"Sister-in-law, weigh good and ill within your mind. Do not address the traveller in broken, harsh words."*

O sister-in-law, consider what is right and wrong; do not speak discourteously to the traveller.

> *"Wash his feet; offer him a seat. Console him with gentle words."*

Wash his feet, give him a place to sit, and offer reassurance in a sweet voice.

> *"O friend, it would be wrong to send him so far away. Honour him all the more."*

O friend, it is improper that the traveller should have to go so far from here; show him still greater regard.

Scene 4

The young woman and her sister-in-law have arrived in a town and found a place to stay. A traveller asks for lodging, and the young woman sings while the sister-in-law explains the meaning after every line. Four lines then sound from offstage, without any accompanying explanation. The young woman resumes singing, and the sister-in-law once more gives the meaning. Finally Vidyāpati enters and sings the last two lines. At the scene's end, the sister-in-law says: "You did not like it when I turned a traveller away that day. Then why did you refuse this traveller a place to stay today?"

In the Kolāra rāga (from the Vidyāpati Padāvalī preserved in Nepal):

> *"I am alone; my beloved is not in the village. That is why I hesitate to offer a place for the night."*

I am alone and my beloved is not in the village. That is why I am uncertain about asking someone to stay the night.

> *"Elsewhere I would gladly have found you lodging; but I can see no one else even in the neighbourhood."*

Had somebody been nearby, I could have directed you to another place for lodging.

"Forgive me, traveller; please go your way. Wander through the town and seek lodging elsewhere."

O traveller, forgive me and go. Look for a place to stay somewhere else in town.

"Between us stretches an open wilderness; evening has fallen. Living far from home, take care for what lies ahead."

There is open country in between; it is evening, and a traveller in a foreign place must act with the future in mind.

"My mind breaks apart from moment to moment; how long shall I hide my youth when the god of desire has awakened?"

"Go, go, traveller, please … seek lodging elsewhere as you wander through the town."

"Seven and five houses were prepared; distance opened between us when my beloved departed abroad."

"Twelve years had passed; four years have passed since his departure."

"Black thunderclouds pierce the night: weigh carefully whatever you decide to do."

The clouds are dreadful. This is a matter concerning the night; think carefully before deciding.

"Vidyāpati says: such is the custom of the city—love may arise from words of feigned rebuke."

Vidyāpati says that this is the way of town-dwellers: sharp or contrary words can give rise to affection.

Scene 5

Vidyāpati is absent in this scene as well. A traveller arrives, but, seeing neither the mother-in-law nor the sister-in-law, feels embarrassed about staying and moves on. The young woman sings.

In the Ghanachī rāga (from the Vidyāpati Padāvalī preserved in Nepal):

"My house would suit the thief called Kāma, the god of desire; an old maid keeps watch."

My circumstances are favourable to that thief, the god of love, though an elderly maidservant stands guard.

"Twelve years had passed; four years have gone by since he left."

It was the twelfth year when he went away, and now four years have passed since then.

"Even the traveller seeking lodging feels shame; neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law is here in company."

Neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law is present, and the traveller too is ashamed to accept accommodation.

"Seven and five houses were made ready; my beloved travelled afar and separation came between us."

He furnished the home for love and then went to another land; distance grew between us.

> *"The neighbouring house seems a hundred yojanas away; every kinsman has gone off in a different direction."*

The neighbour's dwelling might as well be a hundred yojanas away, and all our relatives have dispersed here and there.

> *"The company of people disappears into the dark; the woman next door has barred her gate."*

The gathering vanishes into darkness, and the neighbour has shut the door of her compound.

> *"My mind runs away again and again; how long can I conceal its movements when the god of desire is awake?"*

My mind races at every instant. Desire has awakened: for how long can I keep my movements concealed?

Scene 6

Here, too, neither the sister-in-law nor the mother-in-law nor Vidyāpati is present. A guest arrives just as rain clouds gather and the downpour begins. The young woman sings.

In the Dhanachī rāga (from the Vidyāpati Padāvalī preserved in Nepal):

> *"I was sitting within my own home; no one else was in the house."*

I was sitting in my own house, and nobody else was there.

> *"Just then a traveller came as a guest, and the heavens began to rain."*

At that moment a traveller arrived as my guest, and rain began to pour.

> *"Who knows what the spiteful neighbour will say, now that she has an occasion for gossip?"*

I do not know what the jealous woman next door will say, now that she has found a chance to speak.

> *"Pitch darkness, unbroken rain: even daylight seems to be night."*

It has begun to look like night even though it is day.

> *"To whom can I tell this? Who will believe me, when the Five-Arrowed One is renowned throughout the world?"*

To whom shall I speak, and who will believe me? After all, the fame of Kāma, the god of love who carries five arrows, has spread across the world.

Scene 7

The body of the mother-in-law is carried off from one side of the stage after her death, and darkness falls across the stage. When the lights return, the sister-in-law's husband takes her away to her marital home. The traveller stands in the aisle among the spectators. Gesturing towards the audience, the young woman sings, while Vidyāpati explains the meaning after every line. In

the last two lines Vidyāpati speaks both the verse and its explanation, repeating those lines and their meanings several times.

From the Padāvalī edited by Nāgendranāth Gupta:

> *"My mother-in-law has died; my sister-in-law too has gone to her husband's home."*

My mother-in-law has passed away, and my sister-in-law has also departed for her marital home.

> *"No one like them remains, with whom I might pass the waking night in conversation."*

There is no one left with whom I can even converse.

> *"Such is the custom of this town: no one asks after anyone else."*

Such is the conduct here: nobody enquires about anybody.

> *"Tell my beloved: how many days must I, a woman alone, remain thus?"*

Tell my beloved how long I must go on living alone.

> *"Traveller, speak to my husband; how long can the radiance of a passionate woman like me endure?"*

Traveller, please tell him: how long will the glow of passion in a woman such as I last?

> *"Vidyāpati sings: the woman separated from her beloved wanders and wanders, entreating the traveller."*

Vidyāpati sings that the woman, wandering in separation, keeps explaining her plight to the traveller.

As Vidyāpati sings, he staggers slightly. Darkness begins to spread, and a figure can be seen dimly approaching the young woman out of the shadows. Could this be the beloved who went away? Yes—or perhaps not!

Piyā Desāntar ends, and the curtain falls amid music.

This conception of Piyā Desāntar is offered to discerning audiences. Amid the present distress of Maithils who have gone away in search of work, it is respectfully dedicated to the great poet Vidyāpati.

(Vidyāpati's verses are taken from the Vidyāpati Padāvalī edited by Nāgendranāth Gupta.)

Appendix 4: The Journal of the Bihar Research Society, Vol. XLIV, March–June 1958 (Parts I & II): "Earlier Vidyāpatis," Dr Bimanbehari Majumdar.

95. "Love's Vow, or Victory to Śruvavatī!": Female Agency and Inner Strength

Abstract

The first dramatic piece in the Love Tetralogy, *Love's Vow, or Victory to Śruvavatī!*, marks a new turn in Kunal's playwriting. Radically different from the expansive, many-character, song-and-dance-rich world of the Folk-Theatre Trilogy, this short play is economical, incisive and centred on ideas.

Keywords: Śruvavatī; female agency; inner strength; feminist reading; existentialism; mythological reinterpretation.

1. Introduction, Dramatic Architecture and the Central Question

The first play in the Love Tetralogy, *Love's Vow, or Victory to Śruvavatī!*, represents a new turning point in Kunal's dramatic writing. Unlike the Folk-Theatre Trilogy, with its multitude of characters and its profusion of songs and dances, this play is restrained, sharp and driven by thought. The stage directions themselves specify "a three-level stage; its levels are used at times as platforms, at others as stairs." There are only four performers—two actors and two actresses—who undertake several roles: Bhāradvāja, the old man, Vasiṣṭha and Indra may be played by the same one or two actors, while Śruvavatī, her friend and other women are played by one or two actresses.

The source is a Purāṇic narrative about Śruvavatī, daughter of the sage Bhāradvāja, who is mentioned in several mythological contexts. But Kunal's Śruvavatī goes far beyond the conventional story. She does not reject the established role of a "marriageable daughter"; rather, she insists on defining the conditions of marriage herself: "As soon as someone becomes meaningful to me, I shall marry!" This demand that the prospective partner should become "meaningful" is the play's central philosophical and dramatic question.

The drama unfolds in five movements: (1) Śruvavatī declares before Bhāradvāja that she is "free and self-reliant"; (2) on the riverbank she experiences love on seeing Indra's shadow; (3) Indra appears in person and proposes that she come to heaven "after death," a condition she refuses; (4) Indra, disguised as an old man or as Vasiṣṭha, tests her with a miraculous fruit, which turns to stone; and (5) Śruvavatī resolves to enter the funeral pyre, Indra accepts her, and the play closes with a couplet by Duṣyant Kumar.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 The Classical Form of the One-Act Dramatic Piece and the Division into Acts

Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* distinguishes dramatic forms according to their extent and structure. Within the *Daśarūpaka* tradition, the *nāṭikā* is a relatively short form: ordinarily with fewer than four acts, a single central love story, a predominant heroine and an admixture of pathos. The word *urf* ("also

called") in the title brings together an elite classical tradition and a popular idiom: *Prem-Pratijñā* ("Love's Vow") has a classical resonance, while *Śruvavatīk Jay!* ("Victory to Śruvavatī!") sounds like a popular acclamation.

The three-tiered stage is a modern transformation of the *Nāṭyaśāstra* conception of the *raṅgamaṇḍapa*, or theatrical space. In the interpretation offered here, Bharata's stage has three parts: the *raṅgaśīrṣa* above, the *raṅgapīṭha* in the middle and the *nepathya* behind the scenes. Kunal reinterprets this spatial division: at the upper level stands a male announcer or *sūtradhāra*; the middle level carries the principal scenes; and the lower level signifies the natural world of trees, plants and riverbank.

2.2 The Theory of Rasa: Three Forms of Śṛṅgāra Together

Three forms of the erotic or love *rasa*, *śṛṅgāra*, appear together in this play: (a) *saṃyoga-śṛṅgāra*, love in union or anticipated union, evoked by attraction and the sight of a shadow on the riverbank; (b) *viyoga-śṛṅgāra*, love in separation, expressed by Indra's repeated refusals and the pain of Śruvavatī's waiting; and (c) devotional *śṛṅgāra*, in the stringing of a garland "to place around the neck of the deity of my heart." Bharata identifies *rati*, love, as the enduring emotional disposition (*sthāyibhāva*) of *śṛṅgāra*. The reading pursued here also speaks of *parama-rati*, a love beyond the senses, as its highest state. Śruvavatī becomes the embodiment of that supreme love.

Karuna-rasa, the sentiment of pathos, likewise has a distinctive presence: "What use is a heart that carries no remembrance of the beloved?" This expresses not simple grief but a philosophical sorrow in which the value of life itself is questioned. Abhinavagupta's *śānta-rasa*, the mood of tranquil acceptance beyond all worldly relations, is read into the concluding scene.

2.3 Dharmaśāstra and Women's Freedom: A Political Reading of the Play

A familiar passage from the *Manusmṛti*—"The father protects her in childhood, the husband in youth"—distributes the obligation to "protect" a woman among father, husband and son. Bhāradvāja upholds this convention: "A woman should live with her brother, father or husband." Śruvavatī challenges the Dharmaśāstric norm with a question: "Why? Can I not protect and look after myself, Father?"

The cultural significance of her question is extraordinary. It concerns more than personal independence: it is a dramatic challenge to a Dharmaśāstric rule from within the Maithili tradition of mythological theatre. Bhāradvāja's final response—"Remain happy, whether as a housewife or as an ascetic"—shows that he too finally accepts her right to decide for herself. At that dramatic moment the patriarchal structure yields ground. It is a further development in the sequence of women-centred figures in Indian drama and thought—Maitreyī, Gārgī and Śakuntalā.

2.4 A Vakrokti Reading: The Multiple Resonances of "Meaningful"

Read through Kuntaka's theory of *vakrokti* and Ānandavardhana's theory of *dhvani*, the word *arthavān* ("meaningful") becomes the most important word in the play. In its direct or denotative sense (*abhidhā*), it means "important" or "useful"; by secondary indication (*lakṣaṇā*), it means "one who leads a life of significance"; and through suggestion (*vyañjanā*), it means "one who gives meaning to my existence." The third meaning is the philosophical soul of the drama. Śruvavatī is seeking neither beauty nor wealth nor martial prowess as an external criterion, but an inward relationship of meaning.

The obliqueness, or *vakrokti*, of the word lies in this reversal: Indra, king of the gods, all-powerful, married many times and sovereign of heaven, fails the test of becoming "meaningful" to a sage's daughter. Only in the scene at the pyre does he finally establish himself as meaningful. The inverted trial combines poetic indirection with irony.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Simone de Beauvoir: *The Second Sex* and Female Agency

The French feminist philosopher Simone de Beauvoir (1908–1986), in *The Second Sex* (*Le Deuxième Sexe*, 1949), wrote that "one is not born, but rather becomes, a woman." She argued that women's otherness is a social and cultural construction.

Śruvavatī's characterization offers a mythological dramatic illustration of this proposition. Her father's guardianship, a marriage proposal from a royal household and Indra's offer of heaven "after death" are all attempts to make her an object. She refuses each attempt and asserts herself as an acting subject. Her final words—"I had accepted you all along, beloved! You yourself say it!"—mark the culmination of that agency. The victory belongs to her.

3.2 Sartre: Existentialism and the Making of Meaning

The French philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre (1905–1980) expressed a central claim of existentialism in the proposition "existence precedes essence." Human beings do not arrive at birth endowed with a predetermined essence; through free decisions they define themselves.

Śruvavatī's outlook is a mythological-dramatic counterpart to Sartrean existentialism. Being the daughter of a sage is an inherited "essence"; becoming an independent, self-reliant person is her self-fashioned "existence." Her words—"You yourself said that exceptions confirm the rule. Let me be the exception, Father!"—give the idea of Sartre's "radical freedom" a Maithili expression.

Sartre used *mauvaise foi*, or "bad faith," for the condition in which a person denies freedom and seeks refuge in convention and commands. Indra's attempts at disguise—as an old man and as Vasiṣṭha—become a divine version of such bad faith: the king of heaven conceals his true identity in order to

administer a test. Śruvavatī pierces every disguise: "I was already married the moment I gave him a place in my heart."

3.3 Bakhtin: Polyphonic Drama and Dialogism

In his theory of dialogism, Mikhail Bakhtin argued that language is inherently many-voiced or polyphonic: several voices reverberate within each word. The most striking instance of dialogism in this play is the Urdu couplet at its close.

The celebrated couplet of Duṣyant Kumar (1931–1975) asks: "Who says the sky cannot be pierced? / Throw a stone with all your strength, my friends." It surfaces unexpectedly at the close of a Maithili mythological play. In this many-voiced ending, three linguistic and cultural traditions meet in a single moment: Maithili mythological storytelling, Hindi–Urdu poetry, and modern political consciousness, for the breach in the sky signifies making the impossible possible. It is a distinctive dramatic instance of Bakhtinian *heteroglossia*, the encounter of different social languages.

3.4 Peter Brook: The Empty Stage and Theatrical Economy

In *The Empty Space* (1968), the British director Peter Brook (1925–2022) proposed that one person crossing an empty space while another watches can be enough to create an act of theatre. His notion of "Holy Theatre" places an emphasis, in the present reading, on the reduction of visual paraphernalia so that the spectator's imagination may become active.

The three-tiered, largely empty stage of this play becomes a specifically Maithili mythological version of Brook's "empty space." The direction that levels may function sometimes as platforms and sometimes as stairs refers not to elaborate scenery but to the possibilities of spatial transformation. Indra's disappearance and reappearance, the fruit turning to stone, and the building of the pyre are created through changes in light and the actions of performers, not through heavy stage apparatus. This reading connects Brook's "Holy Theatre" with the awakening of the spectator's self-awareness.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Yuanfen: Fate-Bound Love and Śruvavatī's Challenge

In Chinese cultural and philosophical traditions, *yuanfen*, a relationship of destiny or fate-bound love, is an important concept: a preordained, almost divine thread joining two souls. In Chinese poetic drama, the fulfilment of this destined connection is often made the aim of the plot.

Yuanfen enters the relationship between Śruvavatī and Indra in a complicated way. She calls Indra "the god of my heart" and strings a garland for him: in these actions she acknowledges the bond. But she rejects Indra's condition that their union must take place "after death," thereby redefining it. In effect she asserts that destiny may provide the bond, but she herself will determine its timing and terms. This is a subtle expression of female agency.

4.2 Kaoyan: The Dramatic Tradition of the Trial

Kaoyan, a test or trial, is an important dramatic device in classical Chinese theatre. Many folktales and plays require lovers to establish their fidelity through extraordinary ordeals. A test of constancy also stands at the centre of dramatisations of the well-known *Liang Zhu*, or *Butterfly Lovers*, narrative.

In Kunal's play the structure of *kaoyan* is reversed. Ordinarily the hero's fidelity is examined; here the heroine is initially the one tested, through Indra's seemingly miraculous fruit. But the examiner becomes the examined when Śruvavatī's resolution to enter the pyre unsettles Indra himself. This reversal contributes to the play's originality: the person administering the test is subjected to a test in turn.

4.3 Yizhi: Moral Will and Neo-Confucian Ethics

Neo-Confucian thinkers, especially Wang Yangming (1472–1529), emphasized *yizhi*, moral volition, and *zhi liangzhi*, the extension or realization of innate moral knowledge. They held that human beings possess moral knowledge within themselves, rather than receiving it solely through external imposition.

In this Yangmingian sense, Śruvavatī is a character endowed with *yizhi*. Her insistence on a meaningful partner, her declaration to the disguised Indra that she belongs to another, and her resolution at the pyre are moral decisions that arise from within rather than from lessons imposed from outside. The dramatist's message—"Inner strength is a human being's greatest wealth"—has a striking affinity with the philosophy of Wang Yangming.

4.4 Beiju: Chinese Tragedy and the Play's "Victory"

Chinese dramatic criticism has debated whether Chinese theatre possesses "tragedy," or *beiju*, in the Western sense. Wang Guowei argued that classical Chinese plays present distressing circumstances but often end through reconciliation or accommodation. The account cited here characterizes this partial tragedy as a sorrowful quest.

The word "Victory!" in the title establishes that this is not simply *beiju*, but a form of *bei zhong you xi*, joy within sorrow. The transformation of the fruit into stone and the resolve to enter the pyre are painful; Indra's acceptance and the proclamation of victory bring reconciliation. What matters most, however, is that Śruvavatī, not Indra, is the heroine of the victory. This is a significant reversal.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Hanoch Levin: The Dramatic Defence of Human Dignity

The Israeli dramatist Hanoch Levin (1943–1999), among the country's most important playwrights, repeatedly confronted the question of what social arrangements threaten human dignity and how that dignity might be

defended. In plays such as *The Labour of Life*, women characters often struggle to protect their identity against social and familial pressures.

Śruvavatī's predicament resembles that of Levin's women characters but differs from it in an essential respect. Levin's women often fail: the system overwhelms them. Śruvavatī is victorious. For this critic, the difference reflects Kunal's optimistic humanism. Instead of Levin's severe realism, Kunal offers an Indian mythological hope in which inner strength eventually prevails.

5.2 Eli Rozik: Multiple Roles and the Iconicity of Changing Identity

Eli Rozik's theory of theatrical iconicity faces a particular test in this play's practice of multi-role performance. A single actor may embody Bhāradvāja, the old man, Vasiṣṭha and Indra.

Rozik's question is: when one performer plays several roles, which "image" does the audience see? His argument, as invoked here, is that the spectator apprehends two images at once—that of the actor and that of the character—and that this double perception is fundamental to the special beauty of theatre. In this play "double iconicity" acquires an additional political meaning. Indra tests Śruvavatī first disguised as an old man and then as Vasiṣṭha, while the audience knows that he is Indra. The resulting dramatic irony makes Śruvavatī's capacity to recognize truth shine still more brightly.

5.3 Post-Holocaust Dramatic Thought: Fire and Existence

In post-Holocaust discussions of theatre associated here with the Israeli scholar Dvora Ben-Shaul and others, fire becomes an intensely charged symbol: it may encompass destruction and survival at the same time.

Read in this light, Śruvavatī's scene at the funeral pyre forms a complex dramatic image. Entering the flames evokes *satī*, an institution associated with patriarchy in Indian history. Kunal reverses the symbol: Śruvavatī's pyre expresses not simply a wish to die but a demand to live on her own terms. She lights the fire herself and declares: "Remembering my beloved, I shall enter the flames." The division she posits is between living with love and being unable to live without it, not merely between life and its rejection. Within the proposed Israeli interpretive framework of a "politics of survival," Śruvavatī acts as a witness, turning her very existence into evidence.

5.4 Yaakov Shabtai: The Closing Urdu Couplet and Intercultural Dialogue

The Israeli writer Yaakov Shabtai (1934–1981), in works such as *Past Continuous*, made language a central aesthetic instrument. In the comparative account offered here, the interaction of Hebrew, Yiddish and Arabic expresses a culturally hybrid world.

The Urdu couplet closing Kunal's Maithili play parallels this intercultural conversation. Maithili, mythological reference and the Urdu poetic tradition meet in a conjunction that is not mere ornament but a cultural and political statement: inner strength does not recognize linguistic borders, and its

message can be expressed as authentically in Urdu as in Maithili. Duṣyant Kumar's invitation to fling a stone at the sky becomes an Urdu restatement of Śruvavatī's resolution at the pyre.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis: The Many Meanings of "Victory"

When all four dramatic traditions are considered together, the central question of *Love's Vow, or Victory to Śruvavatī!* becomes clear: whose victory is this, and what kind of victory is it?

From the Indian perspective: the three kinds of *śṛṅgāra*; the dramatic overturning of Dharmaśāstric expectations about women; the threefold suggestiveness of *arthavān*; and the pyre reinterpreted through the tradition of devotion.

From the Western perspective: becoming a "subject" in Beauvoir's sense; Sartre's radical freedom; Bakhtin's heteroglossia in the Urdu couplet; and Brook's Holy Theatre, represented through an almost empty stage.

From the Chinese perspective: redefining *yuanfen*; a reversed *kaoyan*; Wang Yangming's *yizhi* understood as inner moral strength; and the celebratory resolution of joy within sorrow, *bei zhong you xi*.

From the Israeli perspective: the contrast between Levin's female characters and Kunal's hopeful vision of inner strength; Rozik's double iconicity; fire as the politics of survival; and Shabtai's intercultural dialogue.

The shared conclusion of these four traditions is that Śruvavatī's "victory" is not an individual conquest in love. It is a philosophical victory for *ātmabala*, inner strength—conceived in the Indian context as courage, in the Western context as freedom, in the Chinese context as *yizhi*, and in the Israeli context as dignity. The exclamation mark in the title says as much: this is a proclamation, not a mere description.

Supplementary Narrative Analysis

This play in the collection draws upon narratives from the *Śalya Parva* and *Vana Parva* of the *Mahābhārata*. Through the character of Śruvavatī, the daughter of the sage Bhāradvāja, Kunal gives voice to a woman's sovereignty and right to self-determination.

Determined to marry Indra, king of the gods, Śruvavatī undertakes severe austerities. Indra appears in the guise of the sage Vasiṣṭha and tests her fidelity, commanding her to keep cooking jujube fruits. When the fuel is exhausted, Śruvavatī does not shrink even from burning her own feet in the sacrificial fire. Witnessing her extraordinary bodily suffering and unshaken resolve, Indra is overcome and accepts her as his consort. In this play, Kunal accords the woman dignity onstage not as a petitioner but as the maker of her own destiny.

96. A Critical Review of Kedarnath Chaudhary

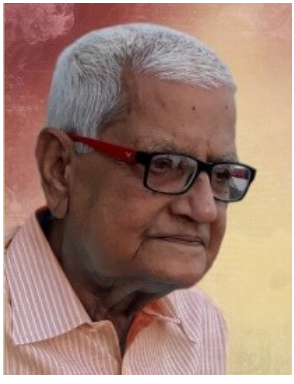
Abstract

I was on night duty. At two in the morning my telephone began to ring. A colleague of mine, a Tamil speaker, was listening to my conversation. "What language were you speaking for an hour? It is such a sweet language," he said.

Keywords: Kedarnath Chaudhary; short stories; Maithili literature; criticism; institutions; readership; language

Stories 1–10

Story 1



Story 2

Dr Kalpana Manikant Mishra

Mother Tongue

I have read and heard a great deal about love for one's mother tongue. You, too, must have heard of it, perhaps many times; but only a few people have had the opportunity to experience it themselves. We had come to Bombay. More than a generation has passed since the events I am about to recount, but I cannot bring myself to forget them. And why should I forget? We were lost in the dazzling lights of the metropolis, anxious not to lose our way. During the 1980s a scheme introduced by Sanjay Gandhi offered unemployed graduates bank loans of 20,000 rupees on certain concessions. I, too, was an unemployed doctor. I applied and the loan was sanctioned immediately. But what should I do with the money now? I could have invested in my own profession—in a dispensary, for instance, or a small house where I might later establish a clinic. Such things were comparatively accessible and possible then; today they would remain dreams at that price. I could have invested the money to secure my future, had jewellery made to satisfy my personal wishes, or travelled around India. But no! My husband, Dr Manikant Mishra, wished to bring out a Maithili-language magazine. Together we started a Maithili periodical called Videha. It was printed, but who would buy it, and who would read it? That was a very serious problem. Somehow, investing our household savings, we kept the magazine running for two years. Then we had to close it. Both of us were engaged in medical practice, and it was exceedingly difficult to manage the demands of home, hospital and family. We were still newcomers to Bombay. In those circumstances, no ordinary person could have ventured so boldly. Only Dr Manikant Mishra could have done so, for his attachment to Maithili was a passion. Neither the frantic pace of life in Bombay nor the ups and downs of his health could diminish his enthusiasm for his language.

Story 3

It was then that I understood that

there could have been no sacrifice;

the path is the one pursued by the obstinate.

Story 4

Those who parade in freshly washed dhotis ought to give up the translation assignments they distribute among themselves through the Sahitya Akademi. Those assignments should instead go to Nand Vilas Rai, Rajdev Mandal, Rambilas Sahu, Dhirendra Kumar, Durganand Mandal, Manoj Kumar Mandal, Shiv Kumar Prasad, Umesh Paswan, Sandeep

Kumar Safi, Bechan Thakur, Meghan Prasad, Kishan Karigar, Laldev Mahto, Umesh Mandal, Shardanand Singh, Subhash Kumar Kamat, Munni Kamat and others. That would raise an entire force of Agniveers for Maithili. Meghan Prasad had expressed this wish in an article in Videha, but even then he was not given a translation assignment. Half-congratulations to Ashok Avichal: under his tenure, only one immaculate dhoti received an award instead of the usual two. What excuses the deceptive, freshly washed-dhoti fraternity, from the forward and backward camps alike, will now invent—and whether next year the Sahitya Akademi will again belong exclusively to these spotless-dhoti wearers—remains hidden in the womb of the future.

Story 5

A Literary Event

Let me describe a literary event. It occurred in the modern period of Tamil literature.

The mainstream summoned scholars from around the world, arranged programme after programme, and publicised them lavishly. Writers of enormous stature—eighty arms tall, as it were—were invited; one glittering programme followed another; radio and television carried the publicity. The mainstream scattered money like confetti. Its first-rate programme came to an end.

And what did the parallel stream do? It brought out an anthology of contemporary alternative prose and poetry titled Kurukshetram. Printed on ordinary paper with an unpretentious design, this Kurukshetram shook Tamil literature. A debate began: of two literary events held at the same time, which had benefited Tamil literature more—the extravagantly funded world, or perhaps cosmic, conference on Tamil literature, or Kurukshetram?

The majority agreed that Kurukshetram, printed on plain paper with a simple design, was the greater event.

Videha's special issues devoted to living writers have become Maithili literature's Kurukshetram. During debates on Facebook, writers acknowledged that Videha's special issues on living authors had acquired greater importance than the Sahitya Akademi awards. In the Sahitya Akademi, through which lakhs upon lakhs of rupees circulate, the lamentation has not subsided. The mainstream has become tangled in its own web: those who secured assignments now strain after awards, those who secured awards strain after assignments, and those who received neither demand both. The condition of those who have received both is worst of all. They receive no particular respect even from the Akademi,

and their writing is not of a quality that could stand before the parallel stream. If there are exceptions, some have sunk into depression, while others have begun declaring themselves marginalised, or members of the alternative stream.

In other words, declaring oneself marginalised, or claiming allegiance to the alternative stream while remaining in the mainstream—whose immense, eighty-arm-tall writers come from both the forward and backward communities—has become fashionable. But this is no mere fashion …

Story 6

How Does One Become a Scholar?

The Letter (Akshar) Pillar

Story 7

Now for Some Speechmaking

Story 8

Story 9

The Saketanand Affair

He writes:

Story 10

This Is No Story

97. "The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage": Faith, Recognition and Transformation

Abstract

This review of the Sukanya–Chyavana narrative places questions of faith, vision, identity, appearance and spirit, marital fidelity, and moral agency at its centre. Comparative threads drawn from Indian philosophy, recognition, psychological identity, the heart's vision, transformation, and Jewish-Israeli conceptions of intimacy expand the play's structure of meaning.

Keywords: Sukanya; Chyavana; faith; identity; recognition; vision of the heart; transformation

1. Introduction, Dramatic Architecture and Distinctiveness

The second short play in the Love Quartet, The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage, is based on the Sukanya–Chyavana episode in the Shanti Parva of the Mahabharata. Kunal, however, rewrites this traditional tale from a new feminist-philosophical perspective. Its naming is significant: "The Power of Faith" identifies the governing idea, while "Sukanya's Marriage" names the event of the story.

The play's architecture is exceptionally well organised. Its five dramatic sequences are: (1) the spring festival—the narrator, Vidyapati's "Ayal Ritupati Raj Basant" ("The Lord of Seasons, Spring, Has Arrived"), and the contrasting philosophies of king and queen; (2) Chyavana's anthill-covered meditation and Sukanya's accidental injury to him while playing; (3) Chyavana's forgiveness and proposal of marriage, the king's uncertainty, and Sukanya's freely given consent; (4) life in the hermitage and the Ashvini Kumaras' deceptive test, involving three identical forms; and (5) Sukanya's test of the eyes, Chyavana's rejuvenation, the granting of soma, and the conclusion.

The play's central dramatic question is: what is faith? Does it arise from the eyes or from the heart? When three identical figures stand before a woman, by what means does she recognise her husband—through the body or through the soul? The dramatic answer—"Affection, envy, compassion: they surge within these eyes"—constitutes the ideological climax of the play.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 The Mahabharata Source and Its Re-reading: The Politics of Dramatisation

In the Sukanya–Chyavana episode of the Mahabharata's Shanti Parva, Sukanya is an obedient daughter who marries the elderly Chyavana at her father's command. In place of this "obedient daughter", Kunal presents a woman capable of choosing for herself. In the Mahabharata the marriage is her father's decision; in this play Sukanya herself declares, "The offence is mine; I shall make amends," and voluntarily becomes Chyavana's wife.

Such "epic rewriting" belongs to an established tradition in Indian women's writing: retellings of the original epics from the perspectives of Urmila in the Ramayana, Draupadi in the Mahabharata, and others. As a male author, Kunal demonstrates a conscious engagement with that tradition.

2.2 The Theory of Rasa: Three Phases of Shringara and the Triumph of Wonder

The movement of shringara-rasa in this play assumes a distinctive dramatic outline: (a) the opening spring song, Vidyapati's "Ayal Ritupati Raj Basant", provides an elevated poetic entrance into the erotic-aesthetic mood; (b) the piercing of the anthill brings compassion and fear—the accidental wound inflicted during Sukanya's play, Chyavana's anger, and her guilt; and (c) the life of the hermitage brings a shringara of trust, as Sukanya, dressed in bark-cloth, says, "I live like an ascetic; I was happy then, and I am happy now."

The culminating moment of adbhuta-rasa, the sentiment of wonder, is the Ashvini test: three identical forms. It exemplifies a special variety of the Natya Shastra's adbhuta—"pleasant wonder". Bharata identifies exertion, joy, envy, despondency, and restlessness among the transitory states of wonder; all are present in this scene.

2.3 The Test of the Eyes: The Significance of Vision in Indian Philosophy

In Indian philosophical traditions, the eye (netra or nayana) is important in several senses: as an organ of direct perception, a "mirror" of the soul, and a medium of union. "Reading the heart through the eyes" has a long poetic history; communication through the eyes is prominent in Vidyapati's songs as well.

In the trial involving "three identical forms", Sukanya's certainty arises from sight—but not from outward sight. It comes from inward vision.

> *Affection, envy, compassion—these surge within the eyes. Passion, tenderness, delight—these dwell within the eyes.*

From the standpoint of Nyaya philosophy, this is "indicative perception": recognition through inner qualities in the absence of distinctive outward appearance. In the vocabulary of Navya-Nyaya, the mark or reason (linga/hetu) establishes the object to be proved (sadhya). Sukanya perceives the "mark" of affection and compassion in the eyes and thereby establishes the identity of "Chyavana" as the conclusion.

2.4 The Chyavanprash Episode: Popular Memory and Dramatic Humour

At the beginning of the play the narrator makes an amusing remark: "Chyavana—the one associated with Chyavanprash? Well … no … let us say … yes, that very one." In this single line Kunal compresses an interval of two thousand years into a comic dramatic instant. The sage Chyavana was renowned for medicinal knowledge; the modern heir to that tradition is the product called Chyavanprash. This is an excellent modern example of the Indian dramatic convention of vidushaka-ukti, the jester's intervention, in which humour and satire enter the solemnity of mythology.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Martin Buber: I–Thou and I–It Relationships

The German-Jewish philosopher Martin Buber (1878–1965), in Ich und Du (I and Thou, 1923), distinguished two kinds of human relationships: I–Thou, in which the other person is recognised as a complete "Thou", a subject; and I–It, in which the other is treated as an object.

In this play the Ashvini Kumaras represent I–It: they seek to reduce Sukanya to a beautiful object ("You see only the body, you speak only of the body"). The relationship between Chyavana and Sukanya embodies I–Thou. Chyavana says, "You enter through the gateway of the eyes and see the heart." This is a dramatic transformation of Buber's Begegnung, the genuine encounter. The reversed direction of the Ashvini test—Sukanya reading the soul through the eyes—is precisely the method of recognition associated here with I–Thou.

3.2 Aristotle: A New Form of Anagnorisis

In Aristotle's Poetics, recognition (ἀναγνώρισις, anagnorisis) is a decisive dramatic moment in which a character discovers an important identity. The finest recognition occurs together with a reversal in the course of the action (peripeteia).

The scene of the three matching faces gives recognition an innovative form: Sukanya identifies her husband among three identical figures. Aristotelian recognition often involves an external sign—a scar, ring, or name. Here Sukanya recognises him by "reading inward qualities": affection, compassion, and tenderness. This "internal anagnorisis" extends the Aristotelian category.

3.3 Erik Erikson: Identity Crisis and the Development of Trust

The American psychologist Erik Erikson (1902–1994) proposed eight stages of human development. The first is "Basic Trust versus Mistrust", and the formation of this fundamental trust provides the basis for the subsequent development of personality.

Sukanya's trust is a mythological-dramatic transformation of Erikson's "basic trust". She comes from a family in which she has heard both the father's philosophy—"Be happy, everything will turn out well", the king's generous optimism—and the mother's—"Do not turn your eyes away from reality", the queen's cautious realism. Beyond both viewpoints, Sukanya constructs her own fundamental trust. Her guilt over piercing the anthill, her freely chosen marriage, and her steadfastness during the Ashvini test together constitute a dramatic journey of "trust formation".

3.4 Brecht: The Politics of Humour and the Irony of the "Demigods"

In Brechtian dramaturgy, comic scenes often carry political satire. From this perspective the Ashvini Kumaras' scene is extraordinary. These "demigods"—inhabitants of heaven, companions of celestial nymphs, and beings called gods—find themselves defeated before a princess living in a forest and wearing bark-cloth.

In terms of Brecht's Gestus, a socially revealing gesture or attitude, the scene amounts to a "class critique": privileged deities cannot comprehend the "human values" lived by an ordinary mortal woman. Sukanya's retort —"You people have no hearts"—is the decisive Brechtian moral-political judgement.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 心眼 (Xin Yan): The Heart's Eye

In Chinese poetics and Buddhist philosophy, xin yan (心眼, the "heart-eye") is an important concept: the inward vision that perceives inner truth beyond outward form. In the Chan Buddhist (禅) tradition, xin yan is treated as a form of the "Dharma-eye".

The central test of the play—recognising her husband among three identical figures—is an exercise in xin yan. Closing her outward eyes ("Sukanya closes her eyes"), she reads the inner qualities revealed by each pair of eyes: pride and arrogance (the first Ashvini), desire, malice and greed (the second Ashvini), and affection, compassion and joy (Chyavana). This is a remarkable dramatic instance of the heart's eye.

4.2 缘 (Yuan): Karmic Connection and the Possibility of Atonement

In Chinese Buddhist-philosophical tradition, yuan (缘, karmic connection) is a central idea: the meeting of two beings is the outcome of previous actions. In this view the karmic connection is not simply a debt contracted in a previous birth; it is also created by choices made in the present moment.

Sukanya's piercing of the anthill is an unintended act: "I did not wish to do it; it happened." But her response—"I am guilty; I deserve punishment"—constitutes a conscious "yuan of atonement", an attempt at karmic rectification. Chyavana's proposal of marriage is the outcome of this connection. In Chinese poetic drama, such a resolution of karma forms an important dramatic arc.

4.3 形神 (Xing–Shen): The Conflict between Form and Spirit

In Chinese aesthetics, the relationship and tension between xing and shen (形神, form and spirit) is a major subject of discussion. Xing (形) denotes outward form; shen (神), inward being. A principle cited in the theory of Chinese painting is rendered here as de qi xing si shen (得其形似神), the attempt to capture spirit through form.

In the play's scene of the three masks, xing, the outward appearance, is identical, whereas shen, the inward spirit, differs. Sukanya's faith is the power to perceive shen beyond xing. The Ashvini Kumaras fail because they can imitate xing but not shen: precisely the distinction emphasised by the Chinese formulation.

4.4 义务 (Yiwu): The Sense of Duty and Sukanya's Moral Development

In the Confucian philosophical tradition, yiwu (义务, moral obligation) is a central value. It is not merely obedience to external rules. According to Mengzi (孟子, Mencius), moral duty arises from an intrinsic disposition towards ren (仁, benevolence and humanity).

Sukanya's dramatic journey reveals a particular sequence of moral obligation: (a) an unintended act, the piercing of the anthill; (b) a recognition of duty through an admission of guilt; (c) a moral decision in her freely chosen marriage; and (d) the manifestation of ren through forgiveness of the Ashvini Kumaras and love for Chyavana. It is a Mencian arc of moral development.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Martin Buber and Israeli Intimacy: The Hasidic Philosophy of Faith

Martin Buber, whose I–Thou philosophy has been discussed in the Western section, is also an important figure in the intellectual traditions of Israeli culture. He was a philosopher of the Hasidic Jewish tradition, in which faith (emunah, אמונה) is a central spiritual and moral value.

In Buber's Hasidic philosophy, faith is not merely intellectual assent. It is a form of surrender or devotion (Hingabe), a turning towards the other with one's entire being. Sukanya's faith is a Hindu-mythological counterpart of this Hasidic emunah: she recognises Chyavana not by calculation but with her whole heart. The title The Power of Faith and Buber's concept of emunah describe the same spiritual journey.

5.2 Eli Rozik: The Iconicity of the Mask and the Crisis of Identity

Eli Rozik's theory of theatrical iconicity faces an unusual test in this play: three seemingly identical performers, with the same clothing, appearance and language. Rozik's question is: "When the image cannot be separated from its referent, what is the spectator seeing?"

The audience perceives three levels at once: (a) the physical presence of three actors; (b) three fictional figures—Chyavana and the elder and younger Ashvini brothers; and (c) Sukanya's "reading of the heart", which distinguishes the referent of each image. In Rozik's terminology, this is a complex instance of "iconic ambiguity", in which the crisis of recognition becomes the very subject of the drama.

5.3 The Jewish Concept of Tikkun Olam and the Drama of Atonement

In Jewish religious philosophy, tikkun olam, the repair or improvement of the world, is an important concept. It holds that human beings have an ethical obligation to mend the world through their actions. At the individual level such tikkun, or repair, begins with teshuva, repentance and transformation.

Sukanya's conduct is presented as a Hindu-mythological analogue of this philosophy of tikkun. She acknowledges the shever (שבר, brokenness) caused by piercing the anthill, undertakes teshuva in the form of confessed repentance, and effects a tikkun in her life by becoming Chyavana's wife. The conclusion of the play—"A fragrant rain of affection continued to flow"—marks the completion of that repair.

5.4 Purim Spiel in Israeli Folk Theatre: Comic Irony

Within Israeli folk-theatrical traditions, the Purim Spiel, or Purim play, is a distinctive form in which traditional narratives receive a humorous and satirical treatment. It allows striking reversals of character and rank, changes of costume, and comic presentations of serious matters.

The Ashvini Kumaras episode is a Hindu-mythological version of this Purim-Spiel mode. The demigods are beings of supposedly elevated status, yet in this scene they become ridiculous, unsuccessful, and exposed to irony. Sukanya's threat—"A man in front and a goat behind"—is a carnival-like inversion reminiscent of the Purim Spiel. Humour and satire directed at otherwise solemn divine figures enliven the action.

6. Fourfold Synthesis: What Is "The Power of Faith"?

Considered together, the four dramatic traditions produce a multidimensional answer to the play's central question.

The Indian perspective: epic rewriting through a freely chosen marriage; shringara, wonder and compassion; the Navya-Nyaya relation between sign and what is established, through the reading of qualities in the eyes; and the jester-like Chyavanprash reference.

The Western perspective: Buber's I–Thou, the relationship of hearts as opposed to objectification; Aristotle's inward recognition; Erikson's formation of trust; and Brechtian class critique, in which demigods are set against the human heart.

The Chinese perspective: xin yan, or vision of the heart; yuan, or karmic connection and atonement; xing–shen, or form versus spirit; and yiwu, the Mencian arc of moral responsibility.

The Israeli perspective: Buber's Hasidic emunah, faith of the whole heart; Rozik's iconic ambiguity; tikkun olam, world repair as a movement from the piercing of the anthill to marriage; and the carnival-like Purim Spiel of the Ashvini episode.

The shared conclusion of the four traditions is that "the power of faith" is not the power of the body or of outward appearance; it is the power of the heart. The play's finest dramatic moment occurs when Sukanya closes her

eyes and, among three identical figures, recognises her husband through the eyes that disclose affection and compassion. From the Indian, Western, Chinese and Israeli dramatic perspectives alike, this is a moment of illumination.

Chyavana's final words—"It could not have happened ... I know you, beloved. You enter through the gateway of the eyes and see the heart"—also provide the closing sentence of this fourfold critical reading.

Supplementary Analysis of Faith

This play recounts the mythological marriage of Sukanya and the aged, blind sage Chyavana. Traditionally, Sukanya has been revered primarily as a devoted wife, but Kunal gives precedence to the psychological power of "faith" in this narrative.

When the divine physicians, the twin Ashvini Kumaras, see Sukanya's beauty and attempt to woo her, she defeats their advances through her fidelity. During Chyavana's rejuvenation, all three—Chyavana and the two Ashvini Kumaras—emerge from the water in the same form. Sukanya uses the "inner eye of faith" to recognise her true husband. In this way the play proclaims the triumph of psychological and intellectual affinity over physical attraction.

98. Kedarnath Chaudhary's Abara Nahitan

Abstract

Kedarnath Chaudhary: A Re-reading of the Author and His Novel. After failing the matriculation examination, he resolved to end his life by leaping from the conveniently situated Ekmi Bridge into the Bagmati's furious current. Even the aroma of jalebis and kachauris fried in pure desi ghee could not dissuade him. He did, however, decide to eat a helping of jalebis and kachauris before killing himself. He would eat at the restaurant, go to Ekmi Bridge, and that would be the end of it.

Keywords: Abara Nahitan; Kedarnath Chaudhary; novel; chapter arrangement; cinematic technique; narrative pace

Arrival in Bombay in Chapter Seven.

Filming in Rajnagar in Chapter Ten.

Shailendra Mohan Jha

Fortunately, I come from Bharwara, the village of that Gonu Jha whom all India knows as the crown jewel of humour. At present I work as a manager with Tata Motors Finance Limited in Sambalpur.

A Dream

I slept one afternoon and had a dream:
I was married, O sister-in-law, to a bride as lovely as the moon.
My dream was shattered, O sister-in-law, in the bright afternoon ...

When I met her, I was delighted;
At the sight of her beauty, sister-in-law, I stood astonished.
I asked her name; she told me it was Rajni.
That beauty of my dreams became the queen of my heart.

She asked me, "Tell me, beloved, how do I look to you?"
I replied, "Listen, darling, you look like the moon.
The moon has blemishes, but you are without a blemish.
Your eyes are like Aishwarya's; your nose like Juhi Chawla's;
Your hair resembles Neelam's, your cheeks Vyjayanthimala's."

After that I asked her, "And how do I look to you?"
She answered, "Not very good; but you are all right, I suppose.
Yet why, beloved, are you so bald* at this youthful age?
You look a little like Sunny, a little like Rahul Roy;
You have a few of Govinda's qualities—that is my opinion."

Then I said, "Come, darling, let us go sightseeing in Darbhanga.
I shall buy a sari for you and an anga for myself.
I have two tickets for Uma Cinema, seats side by side;
Together we shall watch Mamta Gabay Geet.**"
I took her hand in mine and rose to depart;
I took her hand in mine and rose to depart.
Just then Pintua woke me—just then Pintua woke me***—and I awoke from sleep.
My dream was broken, O sister-in-law, in the bright afternoon ...

* My hair is somewhat sparse.

** A celebrated Maithili film.

*** My younger brother.

99. "The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery": Art, Freedom, and Love

Abstract

Taking the conflict between Shweta and Atirath as its centre, this chapter analyses art, love, freedom, detachment, nature, transformation, and the relationship between artist and spectator. Through Indian theories of rasa and dhvani, the modern ideas of Ibsen, Sartre, Camus, and Fromm, the Daoist conception of nature, and Israeli theatrical discourse, it considers both the play's original imaginative conception and its structural tensions.

Keywords: Shweta; Atirath; art; freedom; love; nature; transformation; artist–spectator relationship

1. Introduction, Narrative Architecture, and Distinctive Features of the Composition

The third play of the tetralogy of love, "The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery," is the most original and intellectually daring work in the quartet. Its story is not taken from any traditional mythological source: it is Kunal's independent creation. Shweta, a royal dancer, and Atirath, the "detached" king, are both imaginary characters, yet their conflict gives dramatic embodiment to an enduring philosophical question.

The playwright constructs an extraordinarily daring paradox. King Atirath is a great patron of the arts, a connoisseur of music and dance, affectionate towards his subjects, almost saintly—yet he is "detached": "To fall in love is utter foolishness, a completely pointless occupation!" Opposed to him stands Shweta, a dancer whose seven years of artistic discipline have been stirred by seven years of love, and who insists that "it is impossible to see art without seeing the artist."

The play unfolds in six dramatic sequences: (1) the announcer's introduction, Shweta's dance practice, and Atirath's philosophy of detachment; (2) the encounter at the temple and Shweta's refusal to dance in court; (3) her demand for a private audience and Atirath's angry expulsion of her; (4) Shweta's supposed immersion in water and Atirath's distress; (5) their meeting in the forest and Shweta's transformation —"Desire and supplication belong to my past"; and (6) Atirath's abandonment of his crown and his merging with nature.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 Shweta and the Classical Nāṭyaśāstra's Types of Heroine

Shweta occupies a distinctive position in Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra and its classification of the eight nāyikās, or types of heroine. She is neither the abhisārikā, who goes of her own accord to meet her beloved, nor the svādhīnapatikā, who holds her husband under her sway. Her closest Indian dramatic counterparts are the utkaṇṭhitā, the expectant heroine, and the virahotkaṇṭhitā, the heroine distressed by separation, yet ultimately she passes beyond both. All eight of Bharata's types define love in relation to another person; by the end of the play Shweta dissolves love into the "Supreme Person"—nature and the divine.

This merging corresponds to the ideal of the devotee yearning in separation in the Indian bhakti tradition: Mirabai's "madness" and Radha's "frenzy," in which the impossibility of worldly love is transformed into the sublimity of devotional love. Shweta's final proclamation—"Here everything that moves, that stands still, and that remains unseen will love me, and I shall love everything"—is precisely the bhakti tradition's declaration of universal love.

2.2 Rasa: The Journey from Śṛṅgāra to Śānta

The most remarkable feature of rasa in this play is the intense experience of śṛṅgāra-rasa in a single character, Shweta, and its transformation into śānta-rasa. Abhinavagupta considers śānta-rasa the highest rasa, in which attachment and aversion are pacified, giving rise to an "impersonal experience of beauty." Shweta's life in the forest is the dramatic manifestation of this śānta-rasa.

The irony of this journey is exquisite. Atirath, always "detached," initially resembles a character embodying śānta-rasa, but at the end he becomes "involved," attached through his love for Shweta; Shweta, who had been passionately attached, becomes "detached," absorbed into nature. The play's dramatic skill lies in this reversal of rasas.

2.3 Dhvani: The Multiple Meanings of "Discovery"

Viewed through Anandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka, the word āviṣkār ("discovery" or "manifestation") in the title is the play's richest bearer of suggestion. In Sanskrit, āviṣkār denotes, at the level of abhidhā, "disclosure/discovery"; at the level of lakṣaṇā, "revealing oneself" (Shweta's self-disclosure before Atirath); and at the level of vyañjanā, "discovering oneself" (Shweta's discovery of her own supreme love).

In this third sense, "discovery" becomes an epistemological event. Through her failure to win Atirath, Shweta "discovers" a higher form of love: "Now I have come to know the true nature of love." The refrain from Kusma–Salhes—"As a flower without nectar, so what is life without love?"—is quoted by Shweta in this play, and at the end she finds that very "nectar" in nature.

2.4 Dramatic Craft: The Triangle of Art, Artist, and Spectator

Atirath's philosophy—"The body matters only because it is the vehicle of art"—raises an important controversy in Indian aesthetics. In his Abhinavabhāratī, Abhinavagupta argues that rasa comes to fruition only when the spectator is a sahṛdaya, a receptive and sympathetic participant: not through "identification" with the artist's personality, but through the experience of art. In this sense Atirath's position is an extreme form of Abhinavagupta's theory of the sahṛdaya.

Shweta, however, exposes its limits: the attempt to separate art from the artist is an "artificial discrimination between milk and water." An artist's emotions, body, and lived experience all enter into art; there can be no art completely "apart from the artist's body." This dramatic-philosophical dispute remains a living question in aesthetics.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Ibsen and Nora: Freedom after the Rejection of Love

The Norwegian playwright Henrik Ibsen (1828–1906), in A Doll's House (1879), depicts Nora Helmer, a woman who breaks with society's, her husband's, and her family's expectations and moves towards freedom. Nora's departure is not an escape from society's so-called "duties"; it is a departure in search of her own identity.

Shweta's departure into the forest parallels Nora's, but with an important reversal. Nora leaves by "closing the door"—taking leave of a society she has rejected; Shweta walks "with arms outstretched" towards nature, advancing towards a new relationship. Nora's departure is solitary; Shweta's is bound up with Atirath, who removes his crown and follows her. This is a new theatrical step beyond Ibsen.

3.2 Sartre and Camus: The Philosophy of Revolt and the Absurd

The French existentialist Albert Camus (1913–1960), in The Myth of Sisyphus (1942), analyses the experience of the "absurd"—the collision between the human desire to find meaning and the silence or resistance of the world. In response to this collision, Camus declares that "one must imagine Sisyphus happy."

Atirath's "detachment" is an absurd condition in Camus's sense: a handsome, sensitive connoisseur of art who declares love to be "a pointless occupation." Shweta revolts against this absurdity: she stops dancing in court, places a garland at his feet in the temple, and asks to speak to him alone. She is a female dramatic version of Camus's "rebel" (l'homme révolté).

The play's final reversal, when Atirath removes his crown and enters the forest, is a form of Camus's "joy of Sisyphus." Joy in relinquishing a burden—the royal throne—is a dramatic embodiment of Camus's philosophy.

3.3 Erich Fromm: "Love Is an Art"

The German-American psychoanalyst Erich Fromm (1900–1980), in The Art of Loving (1956), declares: "Love is an art. Like any art, it requires learning, practice, and dedication." Fromm argues that most people regard love as an "object" they can "find," whereas it is actually a "capacity" that must be developed.

Shweta's seven years of discipline—not merely in dance but also in love—constitute, in Fromm's terms, the practice of the "art of loving." Yet the most significant moment in Shweta's intellectual journey, seen from Fromm's perspective, is her declaration: "Now I have come to know the true nature of love." In this "true nature," love ceases to be desire centred on one individual and becomes a "universal feeling." In Fromm's terminology, this is "mature love."

3.4 Egon Wellesz and "Epiphany": The Culminating Dramatic Moment

The Irish writer James Joyce (1882–1941) introduced the notion of "epiphany," a moment of revelation in which an entire truth suddenly becomes manifest in an ordinary instant, into his literary thinking. This idea was developed in theories of theatrical epiphany associated with the dramatic critic Egon Wellesz and others.

Shweta's sight of the stars beside the river is a "dramatic epiphany": "A sky filled with thousands upon thousands of stars. How affectionately they are looking towards me!" An ordinary scene by the forest river suddenly becomes a vast "revelation of meaning": "Why did this thought never occur to me before?" Shweta's intellectual transformation takes place at that instant. It is a Maithili theatrical version of the Joycean–Welleszian "epiphany."

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 无为 (Wuwei): Atirath's Detachment and Daoist Non-Action

In the Daoist philosophical tradition (Laozi, sixth century BCE), wuwei (无为, "non-action," or action without contrivance) is a central principle: "The Dao does nothing, yet nothing is left undone." Wuwei does not mean passivity; it means action freed from "artificial intervention."

Atirath's detachment is a distorted form of wuwei. He does not interfere with the natural flow of art (appropriate), but he also refuses to "interfere" with the flow of human feelings (unnatural). From a Daoist perspective, he suffers not from wuwei but from "strained inaction," an enforced passivity. Shweta's accusation—"You have built a glass palace of false proprieties all around yourself"—is precisely this Daoist criticism.

4.2 自然 (Ziran): Identification with Nature and Shweta's Forest Life

In Daoist-Buddhist thought, ziran (自然, "naturalness") is a high ideal: breaking through human-made barriers to become one with the "natural flow." In the Chinese shanshui (山水, "mountain–water") tradition of painting, the human being is a tiny figure dissolving into the immensity of nature.

Shweta's forest life is a dramatic example of ziran. Having left behind the palace, the pleasure pavilion, ornaments, and throne, she lives among "trees, fruits and flowers, a stream flowing without cease, and the open sky." The Daoist idea of ziran resonates throughout this life. The announcer's final words—"They mingled with the music of nature and became one with it"—mark the culmination of ziran.

4.3 变 (Bian): Change and a Dramatic Reading through the I Ching

The I Ching (易经, Book of Changes) is a foundational text of Chinese philosophy, which regards bian (变, "change") as a basic principle of existence. Its teaching, as presented here, is that change is inevitable; whoever accepts it becomes free, while whoever tries to arrest it suffers.

The play presents two responses to change. Atirath flees from change (detachment is his protective armour); Shweta accepts it, even after rejection, undergoing transformation beside the river. From the perspective of the I Ching, Shweta acts like a junzi (君子, "exemplary person"): she moves with the current of change.

4.4 艺术 and 生活 (Yishu and Shenghuo): The Conflict between Art and Life

Chinese aestheticians such as Liu Zhiyuan have analysed the relationship between yishu (艺术, "art") and shenghuo (生活, "life"). They argue that great art springs from life, but art "separated" from life is merely an empty form.

Atirath's philosophy—"The body is only the vehicle of art"—is an attempt to sever yishu from shenghuo. Shweta's objection—"How is it possible to remain detached from the artist?"—corresponds to the argument of this tradition associated with Liu. In Chinese aesthetics, the principle of qi (气, "vital energy") holds that the artist's qi, or life energy, necessarily flows into the work; without that qi, art is lifeless.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Hanoch Levin: The Proprieties of Royal Power and Human Revolt

In plays such as Patience of Stone, Hanoch Levin repeatedly portrays individuals who rebel on a personal level against structures of power. Levin makes use of a particular dramatic technique: the individual's "small rebellion," which shakes a massive structure of authority.

Shweta's decision to stop dancing in the royal court is an excellent example of Levin's "small rebellion." She takes up no weapon and proclaims no revolution: she simply stops dancing. It is a precise, personal, symbolic revolt that brings the entire dramatic machinery of the royal court to a standstill for a moment. In Levin's terms: "one small human being, one great 'no'."

5.2 Eli Rozik: The "Off-Stage" Moment and the Absent Image

In his work Theatrical Image, Eli Rozik analyses the imagistic significance of the "off-stage" moment. What is not shown on stage but remains present in the spectator's imagination often possesses greater dramatic force than what is actually seen there.

Shweta's "immersion in water" is such an off-stage moment: the audience does not witness it, but hears of it through the attendant's words. In Rozik's terms, this "iconic absence" becomes the most dramatically powerful instant: Atirath's response—"It may yet be that the current carried her away and she came to rest somewhere on the bank"—measures the power of that "absence."

5.3 Israeli Theatre and Exile: The Tradition of Displacement

A central theme of Israeli theatre has been galut (גָּלוּת, "exile"). In this tradition of exile, leaving home is not necessarily a fall; it is an "unavoidable journey" in which new meanings are made.

Shweta's expulsion from the pleasure pavilion is a galut, an exile that ends in a kind of teshuvah: a return home, but to a spiritual home. In her forest exile Shweta finds a "new home," becoming one with nature. Atirath's abandonment of his crown and his entry into the forest constitute a "reverse galut": the king leaves his "home," the throne, and comes to Shweta's "home," the forest.

5.4 Israeli Environmental Theatre: The Politics of Becoming One with Nature

Contemporary Israeli theatre has seen the growth of "environmental theatre" and "nature drama" (site-specific theatre), making the human–nature relationship a theatrical subject. From this perspective, artists such as the playwright Yossi Maya have brought the politics of "humanity versus nature" to the stage.

Shweta's closing words—"Here everything that moves, that stands still, and that remains unseen will love me, and I shall love everything"—amount to a declaration of "ecological love" in this environmental-theatrical perspective. The failure of a human relationship, Atirath's rejection of her love, culminates in a "biophilic" expansion towards the living world and its ecology.

6. Fourfold Synthesis: What Does the "Expansion" of Love Mean?

The word "expansion" in the title articulates the play's central question: love "expands," beginning with one person and advancing towards the whole of existence. The four dramatic traditions perceive this expansion from different angles.

> The Indian perspective: the transformation of the heroine longing in separation, in the bhakti tradition, into śānta-rasa; Abhinavagupta's śānta-rasa and the reversal of the rasas of Shweta and Atirath; the three levels of dhvani in "discovery"; and the dramatic debate concerning art and the artist.
>
> The Western perspective: a departure beyond Ibsen's Nora, creating not a rupture but a new relationship; Camus's absurd revolt; Fromm's "mature love" as universal love; and Joyce's epiphany, in which the vision of the stars becomes the moment of transformation.

The Chinese perspective: Atirath's distorted wuwei (无为); Shweta's ziran (自然), or identification with nature; the I Ching's bian (变), or acceptance of change; and the yishu–shenghuo debate between art and life.

The Israeli perspective: Levin's "small rebellion" in the refusal to dance at court; Rozik's iconic absence in the supposed immersion in water; galut–teshuvah, or exile followed by a return to a spiritual home; and ecological love in environmental theatre.

The common conclusion of the four traditions is that the "expansion" of love means breaking free from the limits of one person, Atirath, to merge with nature, the cosmos, and existence as a whole. In this sense, the title makes the most ambitious philosophical declaration of the entire tetralogy of love.

Atirath's abandonment of his crown and his entrance into the forest—the play's final stage image—is a moment of joy charged with irony. He who remained "detached" finally becomes "attached"; and she who had been "attached" becomes "detached." This is the dramatic truth of love's expansion.

Supplementary Discussion of Adaptation

Kunal's play "The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery" is a philosophical and intellectual Maithili adaptation of his Hindi dramatic work Shweta. In Hindi, it was a musical drama based on the imaginative premise of an ichchhadhari nāga, a serpent capable of assuming a desired form.

In the Maithili adaptation the playwright explores, through Shweta's character, the biological and cosmic expansion of love. Love is not confined to relationships between human beings; it extends to all living creatures, nature, and consciousness. Shweta's discovery is that when love reaches its culmination, it crosses every material and species boundary.

100. "The Trial of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra": Knowledge, Trial, and Love

Abstract

This review of the drama concerning Suprabha and Ashtavakra reads physical embodiment and knowledge, the trial of love, a father's curse, philosophical disputation, transformation, fidelity, and the rejection of Urvashi through multiple critical perspectives. Drawing on Indian mythological reinterpretation, the search for meaning, the philosophy of dialogue, theatrical imagery, and the sensibility of hope, it considers the final play as the intellectual culmination of the collection as a whole.

Keywords: Ashtavakra; Suprabha; knowledge; trial; philosophical debate; transformation; fidelity; love

1. Introduction, Narrative Structure, and Place within the Collection

The concluding play of the tetralogy of love, "The Trial of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra," also concludes the collection as a whole, and its position is therefore symbolic: "The Trial of Love" follows "The Expansion of Love" (the sixth play). Its epic scope—fourteen scenes, five settings (hermitage, the city of Mithila, Janaka's court, heaven, and forest), and at least ten characters—is unusual within the tetralogy.

The story derives from the Ashtavakra narrative in the Vana Parva of the Mahabharata, but Kunal turns it into a complete drama of love, incorporating the historical-mythological story of Janaka's court and the debate with Vandi into a broader "trial of love." The first twelve scenes tell Ashtavakra's story; the thirteenth and fourteenth tell Suprabha's.

The play has seven principal dramatic sequences: (1) knowledge and the curse in the womb, followed by birth; (2) Uddalaka's hermitage, the father's absence, and the first meeting with Suprabha; (3) the plan to travel to Mithila; (4) the dispute with King Janaka on the road, the debate with Vandi, and the father's release; (5) Ashtavakra's renewal through bathing in the river; (6) Vadanya's year-long trial and Suprabha's solitary waiting; and (7) the rejection of Urvashi, the return, and the marriage with a garland of white lotuses.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 Re-reading the Mahabharata: The Courage to Place a Disabled Hero at the Centre

The purpose of the Ashtavakra narrative in the Mahabharata is primarily philosophical: the Ashtavakra Gita, the dialogue with Janaka, is a work of self-knowledge. The debate with Vandi constitutes a second narrative level. Kunal adds a third—love put to the test. The result is a three-layered drama: knowledge (the disputation with Vandi), duty (the liberation of the father), and love (marriage to Suprabha).

More importantly, Kunal places a disabled protagonist at the centre of the stage. In the Indian dramatic tradition, the hero's bodily qualities are a criterion of characterisation, as in the Nāṭyaśāstra: the dhīrodātta hero is strong, handsome, and valiant. Ashtavakra reverses these expectations. His body is bent in eight places, yet his knowledge is extraordinary. Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra contains no explicit category for such a disabled hero; Kunal creates a new dramatic paradigm.

2.2 Transforming the Trial by Fire: The Touchstone of Gold

The agni-parīkṣā, or trial by fire, is a major motif in Indian poetry and drama. Sita's trial by fire in the Ramayana is a proof of fidelity in love. Kunal transforms this motif into a "trial by cold": not in flame, but in the loneliness of separation and a year of being kept apart. The concluding couplet makes the transformation explicit:

Just as fire makes gold shine more brightly still,
So, when love endures a trial, it grows more profound.

In this couplet the metaphor of the "touchstone of gold," the testing of gold in fire, is applied to the trial of love. This metaphorical fire—the trial of separation—is subtler and more philosophical than Sita's literal trial by fire.

2.3 A Festival of Rasas: The Convergence of Seven Rasas

Among all seven plays in the collection, this one stages the most expansive festival of rasas. Vīra, the heroic, appears in Ashtavakra's confrontation at court and victory over Vandi; karuṇa, pathos, in the curse pronounced in the womb, separation from the father, and Suprabha's suffering as she waits; adbhuta, wonder, in the renewal of youth through river bathing and the disclosure of Vandi's secret concerning those immersed in water; hāsya, comedy, in the court spectators' address to Ashtavakra as "Lord Hunchback" and in Vandi's laughter; śṛṅgāra, the erotic sentiment, in the love between Suprabha and Ashtavakra; śānta, tranquillity, in Ashtavakra's

rejection of Urvashi; and bhayānaka, terror, in the father's immersion in the river.

Bharata describes the relation between the dominant rasa (aṅgī-rasa) and subsidiary rasas (aṅga-rasa). In this play vīra and śṛṅgāra function as mutually dominant sentiments. The heroic struggle of intellect establishes worthiness for love, while love itself inspires heroism.

2.4 Ashtavakra's Rejection of Urvashi: A Rare Moment in Indian Literature

In the Indian literary tradition Urvashi symbolises supreme beauty: the love of Pururavas for Urvashi, and Kalidasa's Vikramorvaśīya, are classical dramatic expressions of her fascination. Ashtavakra's rejection of Urvashi is a bold dramatic decision against this long tradition. He says: "My Urvashi, Menaka, Rambha … they are all Suprabha. Suprabha alone." This statement consciously dismantles the classical tradition of attraction to the celestial apsarā.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Viktor Frankl: The Search for Meaning and the Transformation of Suffering

The Austrian psychiatrist Viktor Frankl (1905–1997), in Man's Search for Meaning, sets out a theory learned from his experience in Nazi imprisonment: "logotherapy." Human beings live in search of "meaning," and those who can find meaning in their suffering are able to confront it.

Ashtavakra's life begins in suffering: his father's curse. Yet his mother's revelation, prompted by Shvetaketu's harsh words, gives his suffering a "meaning": "I shall free my father." In Frankl's terminology, this is "self-transcendence"—the dedication of oneself to a meaning beyond oneself. Ashtavakra's entire dramatic journey is an account of that self-transcendence.

From this perspective, the rejection of Urvashi is the highest expression of Frankl's "meaningful life": Ashtavakra turns down the universe's supreme beauty, Urvashi, and the splendour of heaven in order to choose a "meaningful" relationship, his love for Suprabha.

3.2 Sophocles: The Tragedy of Bodily Difference and the Victory of Knowledge

The Greek tragedian Sophocles (497–406 BCE), in Oedipus Rex, portrays a protagonist who comes into life with a "birth defect"—lameness, signified by the name "swollen foot"—and whose entire existence has been

determined by a curse. His quest for knowledge about his birth becomes the cause of his destruction.

The comparison with Ashtavakra is illuminating. Both births are associated with a curse (Oedipus: a paternal curse; Ashtavakra: his father's curse); both lives begin with a search for the father; both are centred on knowledge. The decisive difference, however, is that Oedipus's search for knowledge leads to ruin, whereas Ashtavakra's leads to liberation and love. This contrast reveals a fundamental difference between an optimistic Indian philosophy of drama and the ironic, tragic vision of Greek drama.

3.3 Bakhtin: The Carnivalesque of "Driving Away" and "Coming Together"

Bakhtin's theory of the carnivalesque finds expression in a particular theatrical moment in this play: Ashtavakra's visit to the court. The gatekeeper calls him "Lord Hunchback" while giving way, yet it is this same supposedly "hunchbacked" person who advances the legal and moral case for his right of passage. This is a carnivalesque inversion: the person regarded as the "lowest" in society, because he is disabled, teaches wisdom to the "highest," the king.

The moment of collective laughter after Ashtavakra's victory over Vandi —"Serves him right; he was terribly arrogant"—is Bakhtin's "liberating laughter." The very society that tried to keep the disabled child out of court rejoices in his victory: carnivalesque social justice.

3.4 Peter Brook: The Mahabharata and Mythological Theatre

Peter Brook's Mahabharata (1985, stage and film) was an important experiment: an attempt to transform the epic's immense narrative into a universal human theatrical experience. Brook drew extensively on the Indian dramatic tradition in the process, but approached that tradition from the outside.

Kunal differs from Brook because he writes from within the tradition. By making the Ashtavakra narrative of the Mahabharata's Vana Parva Mithila-centred (Janaka is king of Mithila), and transforming the revelation of Vandi's secret (he is Varuna's son, and water is his home) into a scene mingling comedy and wonder, Kunal offers an "internal revival" rather than Brook's "external reinterpretation."

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 贬谪 (Bianzhe): The Tradition of the Exiled Talent

In Chinese literary tradition, bianzhe (贬谪, the exile or humiliation of a talented official or person) is a major theme. From the poet Qu Yuan (屈原, 340–278 BCE) to Su Dongpo (苏东坡, 1037–1101), many outstanding Chinese poets and scholars were unjustly exiled, yet their talent made them immortal.

Ashtavakra's prenatal curse constitutes a form of bianzhe: even in the womb he was "exiled," alienated from his own body. As in the Chinese tradition of bianzhe, however, his talent transforms that exile into an epic journey. His renewal in the river after defeating Vandi parallels the concluding moment of liberation in the literature of exile.

4.2 忠 (Zhong): Fidelity and Solitary Discipline

In Confucian moral philosophy, zhong (忠, "loyalty" or "faithfulness") is a central value. It is often described as "loyalty to the ruler," but in its original sense it also involves fidelity to one's own word.

The year-long trial reveals the zhong of both lovers. Ashtavakra follows Vadanya's condition "to the letter": even while staying near Suprabha, he deliberately avoids letting himself be seen by her. Suprabha understands her father's hints and "consciously reduces her departures from the hermitage." Their fidelities move in different directions but express the same "meaning": proof of love.

4.3 折子戏 (Zhezixi) and the Play's Episodic Structure

The Chinese tradition of zhezixi (折子, "excerpt plays") helps us understand this play's fourteen-scene scope. Three self-contained zhezixi can be clearly identified: (a) the debate with Vandi, a wholly autonomous dramatic episode set in Janaka's court; (b) the year-long trial, the solitary struggle of Ashtavakra and Suprabha; and (c) the rejection of Urvashi. Each episode could be performed independently as a zhezixi, yet together they constitute one immense "trial of love."

4.4 问答 (Wenda): The Philosophy of Question and Answer and Philosophical Debate

In Chinese philosophical tradition, wenda (问答, question-and-answer dialogue) is a major method of knowing: the dialogues of Zhuangzi (庄子), Confucius's Analects, and the koans of Chan Buddhism. The disputation with Vandi is a dramatic version of this wenda tradition. The announcer's commentary—"Doubt and resolution, refutation and defence, question and counter-question"—describes the structure of wenda itself.

Ashtavakra's first exchange with Vandi resembles a "koan," a paradoxical riddle, in Chinese Chan thought. Vandi laughs at the prospect of "debating scripture with a hunchbacked boy"; Ashtavakra answers: "Wit and laughter serve no purpose; what is called for is philosophical debate." This is the essential spirit of wenda: the seriousness of the question makes mockery irrelevant.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Disability and Israeli Theatre: Ashtavakra's Embodiment

"Disability theatre" is an important contemporary movement in Israel, involving accessible and inclusive performance (nagish, נגיש) that places disabled performers at the centre of the stage. In this tradition the body is not a "deficiency" but an expression of "different ability."

The dramatic representation of Ashtavakra is an Indian-mythological version of this movement, presented three decades before it. He neither "hides" his body, bent in eight places, nor apologises for it. He declares: "My body is indeed bent in eight places. But intelligence has nothing to do with age or appearance." Within this one sentence lies an entire philosophy of "disability justice."

5.2 Eli Rozik: Bathing in the River and the "Image of Transformation"

Within Eli Rozik's theory of theatrical imagery, the "transformation-icon" is an important category: the instant at which a character's "image" suddenly changes on stage and the audience witnesses that change.

Ashtavakra's becoming "straight and healthy" after bathing in the river is a "transformation-icon" that can be represented visually through performance. From Rozik's perspective this moment has a double imagistic significance: (a) bodily transformation, from bent to straight,

and (b) spiritual transformation, from son to sage. The spectators witness both at once.

5.3 The Jewish Talmudic Tradition and Debate: A Parallel to the Victory over Vandi

The Jewish religious tradition preserves a distinctive culture of debate in the Talmud: pilpul (פלפול, dialectical disputation), through which two scholars uncover truth by argument and counterargument. Within this tradition, the victory of a younger or unexpected scholar is a dramatic pattern.

The debate with Vandi is a Hindu-mythological parallel to pilpul: a young, disabled boy, Ashtavakra, defeats the "great scholar" Vandi through argument and counterargument. Janaka's role as adjudicator is comparable to the beit din (בית דין, "house of judgment" or court) associated with such disputation.

5.4 Israeli "Theatre of Hope": Optimism in the Trial of Love

Israeli theatre scholars such as Naomi Lapid have identified a particular tendency, the "theatre of hope," in which an unbroken thread of hope survives even in adverse circumstances. Such "hope" is not naive or simplistic optimism; it is "hope put to the test."

The play's final couplet—"Just as fire makes gold shine more brightly still, So, when love endures a trial, it grows more profound"—is a spiritual declaration of this Israeli "theatre of hope." The final words of the collection—"No feeling surpasses love; its glory has no bounds. Come, let us all unite in one voice and sing love's praise!"—are not merely the triumphal proclamation of the seventh play but of the collection as a whole.

6. Fourfold Synthesis: Why Is a "Trial" Necessary?

When the four theatrical traditions are considered together, they yield an answer to the central question of this play, and indeed of the whole collection: a "trial" does not merely "prove" love; it "matures" it.

> The Indian perspective: the courage, in terms of the Nāṭyaśāstra, to place a disabled hero at the centre; the festival of seven rasas; the transformation of a trial by fire into a "trial by cold"; and the rejection of Urvashi as a dismantling of the apsarā tradition.
>
> The Western perspective: Frankl's logotherapy, or meaning found in suffering; the resemblance to, and difference from, Oedipus (destruction versus liberation); Bakhtin's carnivalesque (a

"hunchbacked" child becomes victor in court); and Brook's external versus Kunal's internal renewal of myth.

The Chinese perspective: the 贬谪 (bianzhe) tradition of exiled talent; 忠 (zhong), or fidelity, in the year-long trial of both lovers; the three-part structure of 折子戏 (zhezixi); and 问答 (wenda), the question-and-answer tradition of Chan and philosophical debate, in the victory over Vandi.

The Israeli perspective: disability justice ("intelligence has nothing to do with age or appearance"); Rozik's transformation-icon in the river-bathing scene; Talmudic pilpul as a parallel to the debate with Vandi; and the theatre of hope in the concluding couplet's affirmation of hope.

The common conclusion of all four traditions is that the "trial" of love is not an externally imposed torment but an inwardly generated "refinement." Just as fire does not destroy gold but purifies it, so a year's solitude in separation does not destroy love but makes it "deeper." In this final play Kunal affirms once and for all the intellectual axis of the entire collection: "Love is truth."

7. The Collection as a Whole: The Intellectual Unity of All Seven Plays

After the fourfold examination of all seven plays, considered as a whole, Kusma–Salhes and Six Other Plays emerges as a coherent intellectual journey.

The intellectual sequence of the folk-theatre trilogy is: Forty Thieves (intelligence) — Bidapat (poetry's immortality) — Kusma–Salhes (love and service to the people): an ethical-philosophical arc.

The intellectual sequence of the tetralogy of love is: Shruvavati (inner strength) — Sukanya (faith) — Shweta (the expansion of love) — Suprabha (the trial and maturation of love): a progression of philosophical development.

The thread binding the entire collection is its concluding refrain: "Love is truth, love is fragrance, the spirit of love endures forever;
As a flower without nectar, so what is life without love?" It echoes from the closing song of Kusma–Salhes, the third play, to the self-revelation in Shweta's Discovery, the sixth. This is the manifesto of Kunal's dramatic work as a whole: "Love is the supreme human value." The collection's contribution lies in affirming this value through three modes—folk tradition, classical tradition, and independent imagination—and testing it against the standards of four theatrical civilisations.

Supplementary Philosophical and Narrative Discussion

Based on the story of the marriage of the sage Ashtavakra and Suprabha, the daughter of Vadanya, this play presents the conflict between physical beauty and intellectual and spiritual radiance in a classical form. Ashtavakra is born with his body bent in eight places because of a curse by his father Kahoda, yet in knowledge he stands among the highest exponents of Advaita Vedanta.

To test Ashtavakra's love, the sage Vadanya sends him on a difficult journey northwards, where the goddess Uttara, presiding over splendour and beauty and appearing as a young woman, offers him sensual temptation. Through the integrity of his character and intellect, Ashtavakra passes the test and marries Suprabha. The play establishes that love is not merely an outward beauty visible to the eye; it is an encounter with the inner self.

101. On the Pretext of Premlata Mishra 'Prem'

Abstract

My school friends in Patna had come to regard Maithili speakers as culturally superior. It was not because of Mithila painting or the craft of sikki and mauni. I had asked, "What has suddenly brought this about?" One of them, a Magahi speaker, replied: "I went to one of your programmes in Patna. Unmarried and married women alike were taking part in cultural performances and plays on the stage."

Keywords: Premlata · Mishra · Prem · pretext · also · any · discussion

On the Pretext of Premlata Mishra 'Prem'

This happened a very long time ago. My school friends in Patna had come to regard Maithili speakers as culturally superior—not because of Mithila painting or the sikki-mauni craft. I asked them, "What has suddenly brought this about?"

One of them spoke Magahi. He replied, "I went to one of your programmes in Patna. Unmarried girls and married women were appearing on stage in cultural performances and plays. You people are very advanced."

He had attended some Maithili festival celebration and seen Neelam Chaudhary dance, as well as Premlata Mishra 'Prem' act. He cared nothing for the difficulty women faced in reaching the stage, or for the fact that their number could be counted on one's fingers: he had decided that we were advanced. I, too, attended several such celebrations between roughly the ages of thirteen and twenty-one, and listened to the expert comments.

"Hey, where are the curtains? When Arun Babu and the others put on plays at Kothia, they have curtains of all different colours."

"Babu Kunal is the director. He changes scenes merely by using light and darkness. He knows an enormous amount about drama. He believes that unless curtains are dispensed with, a play cannot be called modern."

"And what about comic interludes?"

"None of that. In Kunal's view those are all fake forms of theatre."

Just then the electricity failed. But the Petromax lamps were ready, and right in the middle of the performance Akku's comic sketch began, with red and green vermilion, involving a woman whose husband was probably employed by the railways.

"Didn't you come on the first day?"

"Nothing worthwhile happens on the first day. Who wants to listen to speeches by those pompous people and their stale, rotten poetry?"

My friend, however, was unconcerned that these theatrical organisations and celebrations, and literature itself, stood precariously on a narrow support. Would he believe what his ears heard, or what his eyes had seen? Maithili literature was advanced; women appeared on its stages; migrant Maithils were united. Why not? What if the members all belonged to one caste? There were characters from other castes in the plays, were there not? After all, those characters were the very ones who drew the applause, even when they delivered their humiliating lines at the top of their voices.

A day sometime in 2009.

A telephone call came.

"My name is Chhatranand Singh Jha. You may not know me. People call me Batuk Bhai."

"I know you much better as Chhatranand Singh Jha. At that time the programme *Bharati* was broadcast on All India Radio, Patna, from 5:30 to 6:00 in the evening, on Thursdays and Sundays. I remember the days as well, because the market in Chitkohra was held on those two days. The two of us brothers would hurry off to buy vegetables and hurry home again by 5:30. And in that programme you were never called Batuk Bhai."

"I am at Premlataji's residence. Best wishes for *Kurukshetram Antarmanak*—and here, Premlataji will speak to you too."

Premlataji also conveyed her good wishes.

Around that time Mantreshwar Jha wrote a satire without naming me. He said that someone had produced a thick book on the *Pañjī*, the genealogical registers, and wanted to revive the system based on them.

If he had read the book before writing about it, why did he write that?

But once discussion began of the defects in the *Pañjī* described in the first chapter (the preface)—including the assertion that Gangesha Upadhyaya, the founder of Navya-Nyāya, was born five years after his father's death, his marriage to a leatherworking woman, and numerous other details—and once I disclosed how Ramanath Jha had misled the author of *History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila* and concealed these details, everyone, including him, fell silent. The real reason for the original opposition to the book on the *Pañjī* had come into the open.

Videha continued to move forward, while the associations and institutions funded by the Sahitya Akademi remained precariously propped up, panting

and puffing yet speaking in affected tones. One of my shortcomings is that I rarely attend meetings of associations. But after an Akademi-funded event in 2012, I came to feel that those exhausted institutions had not the slightest prospect of reform and that, by and large, they hated me and *Videha*. I had attended few events anyway; I stopped altogether.

The calls still come, inviting me to poetry gatherings, seminars and webinars. I decline, even when the invitations come from friends and groups on Facebook. Some people—not all—then speak all sorts of nonsense about me. My only condition is this: become human beings, and I shall come even against my natural inclination, though by temperament I seldom frequent such places.

How Are We to Become Human?

First, the Sahitya Akademi episode. Some had written that I and *Videha* opposed the Akademi because it did not recognise us. It became clear that it did recognise us. The reason for the opposition was instead that a literary figure whom *Videha* had banned for theft was made an advisory member of the Akademi's Maithili section on grounds of caste. This was the caste which, in my assessment, exercised an exclusive hold over that section; all seven literary associations recognised by it were run by people of the same caste. From translation work to every other assignment, it was virtually impossible for anyone of another caste to secure an opportunity. Ninety-nine per cent of the works in its anthologies of plays, essays and stories came from that single caste (and, in any event, these books were printed only to rot in warehouses).

No institution contributed to Maithili's admission to the Sahitya Akademi: it came about solely through the personal efforts of Jayakant Mishra, and consequently, I argue, Maithili speakers derived no benefit from it. A few members of one caste obtain translation assignments worth fifty thousand to one lakh rupees, and then receive a translation award worth another fifty thousand rupees for the same work.

Whether it is Maithili's inclusion in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, Maithili on Wikipedia or Google Translate, or Unicode for Tirhuta and Kaithi, no mainstream institution has contributed to these achievements. How Maithili came to be included in the Constitution's Eighth Schedule is being documented in my English book *A Parallel History of Maithili Literature*. Of course, one can read on Facebook how Google, Wikipedia and the Government of India supposedly trembled before these organisations and individuals. But who would be afraid of someone who cannot even kill a fly? One thing must also be made clear: Durga Puja is more important to Maithili than Vidyapati festivals. First, the amount of newspaper publicity for Vidyapati festivals does not reflect

their popularity; it merely reflects the organisers' control of the media. Second, counting the plays and the Kunjbihari performances, barely ten people assemble; in many places the plays have disappeared altogether. Third, public participation is almost nil. The festivals resemble the Sahitya Akademi, or perhaps the Akademi resembles them, and both are spreading intolerance in society. Durga Puja is celebrated in village after village. People participate; through cultural events, dancing and other activities, it brings together every section of society, women and men alike. It counteracts the hatred spread, in my view, by Vidyapati festivals, the Sahitya Akademi and its funded institutions, and goes further by fostering harmony. This information is for those organisers of Vidyapati festivals who strut about declaring that other castes should celebrate their own heroes if they have the capacity. Let me also make clear that the portrait of Vidyapati circulated by these institutions is itself incorrect. Moreover, they are noisily, and unsuccessfully, trying to present the Vidyapati who wrote in Avahaṭṭha and Sanskrit as the Vidyapati known as the 'cuckoo-voiced poet' (*Kavikokila*).

Does that mean there is darkness everywhere?

No. Otherwise, why would Premmohan Mishra have resigned from the advisory position in the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili section? Look at college cut-off marks: the lowest are for Hindi and Maithili, and those very people, I suggest, are the ones hissing in that advisory committee. How can a human being remain where snakes are hissing? That is why Premmohan Mishra, a chemist, resigned.

How Are We to Become Human Amid Hissing Snakes?

Before reviewing Premlataji's three books, it is necessary to discuss how she laid down her arms amid these hissing snakes. This is a special issue on Premlata Mishra 'Prem', not a commemorative volume of praise.

Premlataji is an artist, a woman artist, a woman artist from an upper caste. I had hoped she would remain an artist, a genuine artist, at the very least a woman artist. But when the test came, she remained neither an artist nor a woman artist. She became a victim of a conspiracy in which she had to abandon both her identity as a woman and her identity as an artist.

The occasion was the Sahitya Akademi Yuva Puraskar of 2022. There were three jurors, two men—Keshkar Thakur and Rajan Kumar Singh—and one woman, Premlata Mishra 'Prem'. Munni Kamat's poetry collection *Antatah* was in contention: Munni Kamat, the author of *Jindagik Mol*, a writer of genuinely feminist poetry. Neither literary quality nor feminism mattered, I contend; caste prevailed. The book received no vote from Keshkar Thakur or Rajan Kumar Singh—and not even from Premlata

Mishra 'Prem'. Everything has its price. Premlata Mishra 'Prem' paid, I argue, the price of becoming vice-president of a so-called literary association recognised by the Sahitya Akademi. She could not stand firm. One's vote belongs to oneself, but hers went with the male majority, the caste majority.

Shekhar Prasang, *O Din O Pal* and *Ego Chhali Sineh*

Shekhar Prasang is a book based on her research on Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary. *O Din O Pal* came close to being an autobiography but stopped short of it: it is a collection of reminiscences. *Ego Chhali Sineh* is a short-story collection, some of whose stories surprised me.

Shekhar Prasang

Shekhar Prasang is based on her research on the celebrated editor Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary. The first chapter discusses his personality and achievements, the second examines his writings, the third his Hindi works, and the fourth offers a conclusion.

In the conclusion to this book, one passage recounts how Udaychandra Jha 'Vinod' went to the *Mithila Mihir* office to meet him, but found him absorbed in writing with his left hand. He completed a composition in a single attempt, making all his cuts and revisions in his mind.

George Bernard Shaw, by contrast, thought so quickly that he wrote in shorthand to avoid breaking the continuity of his thoughts, and his personal assistant then typed the writing out in longhand.

Mithila Mihir trained an army of writers—more than a thousand of them.

O Din O Pal

This book contains twelve reminiscences.

"My Kakka: Yatriji." One incident in this reminiscence deserves mention. Premlataji used to cook with Yatriji's eldest daughter. But Yatriji decided that both should have one day off each week, and that on that day his eldest son, Shobha Mishra, would do the cooking. Premlataji writes:

"Kakka awakened in us a consciousness of our rights."

Indeed, in a country where domestic work is still often regarded as unemployment or work without earnings, this pleased me enormously. Kakka is no longer with us.

"Uncle, Auntie and..." Neither the uncle's name nor the aunt's is given here. I mention this because I am eager to learn the name of this

daughter-in-law of Rahika. Why? Because in this reminiscence, addressing her aunt, Premlataji writes:

"She was the first Maithil woman to appear on stage, and she has always been a source of inspiration to me." Everyone would therefore want to know her name, and I hope Premlataji will supply it. People can go through their entire lives saying "Auntie, Auntie": they know the name of her natal village, yet never learn the aunt's own name.

The same reminiscence also offers evidence of the precarious state of Maithili theatre. Someone makes a sarcastic remark about Premlataji: "... Harimohan Babu is blowing on a rope and turning it into a snake."

"I Stand in the Dock." This reminiscence concerns Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary. He once told her that, while writing a play, Premlata would appear before his mind's eye, and he would write those dialogues expressly for her.

"A Few Words as an Offering to Memory." This is a reminiscence of Pandit Jayanath Mishra, whose 'spiritual daughter', in Premlataji's description, is the *Maithili Mahila Sangh* (Maithili Women's Association).

"Pioneer of Women's Awakening," "Those Moments Kept Dancing," and "Again and Again I Am Swept Away." All three reminiscences concern her natal village, Rahika. Although they do not occur together in the original sequence, I have grouped them for one reason. In the first, her teacher and her father favoured her entrance onto the stage. The villagers, however, prevented it. She did dance to a song at a daytime rehearsal, at the age of thirteen (in 1961). The play was Govind Jha's *Basat*. Govind Jha also enters the reminiscence when Premlataji later moved to Patna and acted in several of his plays. In the second reminiscence she is thirty-seven or thirty-eight years old (1985–86). The same villagers, twenty-four or twenty-five years later, made her chief guest at the village Vidyapati festival and invited her daughter Annu to sing on stage. After coming down from the stage, she saw her teacher Sitanath Jha for the first time in twenty-three years. On hearing Premlataji's name announced, he had risen in haste, leaving his meal half-eaten, to come and see her. The third reminiscence records her rejection of Udaychandra Jha 'Vinod's' request to act in a play at Rahika without rehearsing with her fellow actors. The play was Mahendra Malangia's *Okar Aanganak Barahmasa*. She also writes that one cannot keep everyone happy all the time. (In this very issue Udaychandra Jha 'Vinod' writes that Premlataji had agreed, but that the villagers' fierce opposition confined her to the audience. He was so distressed by her humiliation that no play was staged at the three-day Vidyapati festival in Rahika thereafter.) The third reminiscence also speaks

of a woman close to her who remarked: "Bless Batuk Bhai: your daughter is married now, and you have even begun to speak a little more freely."

"From the Journey of Theatre to the Final Journey." This piece recalls the well-known Maithili theatre director Pandit Trilochan Jha, known as Guruji. Before his arrival, directors were brought in from Hindi theatre. He first worked with the Raj Darbhanga Theatre, which closed. Then comes mention of Calcutta's Moonlight Theatre, which also closed. He next joined a travelling *yatra* troupe there, and became associated with the Maithili theatrical organisation *Mithiyatri* (whose associates included Dayanath Jha, Gunanath Jha and Shrikant Mandal).

When he could no longer sustain the travelling life of a *yatra* troupe, Kamalnath Singh Thakur helped him join the theatre department of the Chetna Samiti in Patna.

Yet here too we find mention of how precariously Maithili theatre was supported:

"...He kept the other members of his family away from the theatre, and even from discussions of the theatre."

"Shrikant Mandal." Shrikant Mandal died on 7 January 1994. He had found a financier for a film based on Rajkamal Chaudhary's story *Lalka Pag*; the contract had been signed and the songs recorded. Premlataji writes that people even heard those songs at that year's Vidyapati festival.

But the death of one person meant the death of an entire institution. Now neither the songs remain nor was the film ever made. A venture built entirely on personal effort had been precariously supported by one person alone: Shrikant Mandal was that sole support. When he died, even traces of his existence and of his songs were lost—or erased.

"Pramila, the Theatre Worker." This reminiscence concerns Shrinarayan Jha, popularly known as 'Sir', and his wife Pramilaji, who oversaw *Bal-Bhangima*, the children's section of the Bhangima theatre organisation. Their sons Sonu and Monu are mentioned, as are Bhavnath Jha of NABARD and the programme *Thahaka*. Then Pramilaji dies prematurely.

"Some Bitter, Some Sweet." The piece recounts several piquant incidents of the sort one might have seen on *The Kapil Sharma Show*.

"A Theatre Worker's Journey." At Batuk Bhai's invitation and under the auspices of Chetna Samiti, Premlataji and the ten-year-old Bharati acted for the first time in 1973. The dancer Rama Das joined in 1974. The male

performers mentioned are Chhatranand Singh Jha (Batuk Bhai), Vedanand Jha, Phanant Jha, Hridaynath Jha, C. P. Jha, Modnath Jha, Asharfi Ajnabi, Goloknath Mishra, Bandhuji and Shambhudev Jha. Besides Chetna Samiti, the theatrical organisations Ranglok, Navangan, Aripan, Bhangima, Aangan and Kala Samiti are discussed. Those who assumed responsibilities included Rabindranath Thakur, Kaushal Kumar Das, Chhatranand, Kumar Shailendra, Prashantkant, Rabindra Raju, Manoj Manuj, Vibhuti Anand, Kunal, Umakant, Kishore Keshav, Rohini Raman, Jagannath Lal Das, Kaushal Mishra and Tarun Prabhat. Among women performers, she mentions Manju Chaudhary, Sudha Das, Tanuja Shankar, Vinita, Sangita, Nivedita, Manju Jha, Abha Jha and Poonamshree. Mridula Sinha is discussed not only as an actor but also for direction and writing. Mantreshwar Jha organised theatre competitions through *Aripan*. But then...

Manju Chaudhary withdrew not only from the stage but even from asking after the well-being of people associated with it. Mridula Sinha, Sudha Das, Poonamshree, Prabha Jha and Nutan Jha left one by one.

Surendra Acharya remained associated until the end.

Tanuja Shankar was an actor and director, but became involved with serials on Delhi Doordarshan. Her younger sister Kanupriya Shankar became associated with the National School of Drama.

Sneha Pallavi, Shilpi and Rashmi—the three daughters of Harihar Prasad, a Hindi fiction writer, filmmaker and scriptwriter—joined. Anand Mohan Jha and his mother Vaidehi Jha are also mentioned. So are Madhulika Anand, Soma Anand, Deepa Anand, Suprita Das, Jyoti, Sunita Jha, Alka, Neetu, Sharda Singh, Neelam Singh, Preeti, Rashmi Mishra, Annu, Mannu, Barkha Singh and Swati Singh.

Then come those who encouraged and proudly involved their own families, including their wives: Lallan Prasad Thakur (Jamshedpur), Ashok Kumar Jha (Mithila Vikas Parishad, Kolkata), Rohini Raman Jha (Aangan, Patna), Pradeep Bihari (Begusarai), Chaturbhuj Ashavadi (Biratnagar, Nepal) and Shyam Sundar Singh (Bhangima, Patna).

Ego Chhali Sineh. This collection contains twelve short stories. One of them, "Ego Chhali Sineh," concerns the widow Sineh's sexual relationship with Kamlesh, his betrayal and disappearance, and her determination to give birth to the child conceived from the relationship. Years later she returned and transferred her homestead land to the very brother-in-law who had once declared that she should be cut up and buried.

Another story in the collection, "Beauty Parlour," concerns an extramarital sexual relationship in which a married man is allowed to pursue an affair with an unmarried woman.

"Return" tells of a mother-in-law and daughter-in-law. The son and daughter-in-law whom the mother-in-law had driven out of the house were the ones who cared for her, and a return followed.

"Unfortunate" is about a child who ran away from home after some incident and eventually returned.

"Bamboo Footbridge" depicts a flood-prone region, the disappearance and subsequent repair of a makeshift bamboo bridge, and the way the bridge and nature jointly bind society together. Last year there was a news report of thieves cutting up and carrying away an iron bridge in Bihar. The situation remains much the same: earlier bamboo bridges were stolen; now iron bridges are stolen.

"Mother" describes the affectionate relationship between Maiya and Kisunma.

"Vaitarani" is another story of the village: help with the funeral feast after a death, and in exchange take title to all the good agricultural land.

"Jumaratan" presents something like a character portrait of a woman attendant at a school.

"Shade" uses the story of Sudha and Radhiya to bring together feminist and caste criticism, showing how the woman bears a double burden of oppression.

"An Injury" describes conversations among women employees after a shutdown is announced in the city.

"Housewarming" depicts how straightforward people are emotionally manipulated into performing tasks for others.

"The Desolate Courtyard" recalls the absence felt on Auntie's death. The new girls sing songs in the style of film music, something Auntie did not like. At her funeral the boys of the entire neighbourhood cut mango branches laden with tiny green fruit and blossoms and laid them on her pyre. If Auntie was not here this time, whom would she let make pickles and preserves? Such love for Auntie… "Sitting in heaven, make plenty of chutney for us…"

"A butterfly counts not months but moments; thus, for it, time is nothing but time."

Annie Ernaux began by writing autobiographical novels, but soon devoted herself entirely to memoirs.

Some stories by Premlata Mishra 'Prem', such as "Ego Chhali Sineh" and "Beauty Parlour," are bold, while "Shade" and "The Desolate Courtyard" offer psychological analysis. Yet her greatest strength is memoir, and with the wealth of experience at her disposal, she can do justice to it through memoir writing, as Annie Ernaux has done. I hope many more reminiscences will emerge from her pen.

Supplementary Discussion

This happened a very long time ago. My school friends in Patna had come to regard Maithili speakers as culturally superior—not because of Mithila painting or the sikki-mauni craft. I asked them, "What has suddenly brought this about?"

"And what about comic interludes?"

"Didn't you come on the first day?"

A day sometime in 2009.

A telephone call came.

Premlataji also conveyed her good wishes.

If he had read the book before writing about it, why did he write that?

How Are We to Become Human?

Whether it is Maithili's inclusion in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, Maithili on Wikipedia or Google Translate, or Unicode for Tirhuta and Kaithi, no mainstream institution has contributed to these achievements. How Maithili came to be included in the Constitution's Eighth Schedule is being documented in my English book *A Parallel History of Maithili Literature*. Of course, one can read on Facebook how Google, Wikipedia and the Government of India supposedly trembled before these organisations and individuals. But who would be afraid of someone who cannot even kill a fly? One thing must also be made clear: Durga Puja is more important to Maithili than Vidyapati festivals. First, the amount of newspaper publicity for Vidyapati festivals does not reflect their popularity; it merely reflects the organisers' control of the media. Second, counting the plays and the Kunjbihari performances, barely ten people assemble; in many places the plays have disappeared altogether. Third, public participation is almost nil. The festivals resemble the Sahitya Akademi, or perhaps the Akademi resembles them, and both are spreading intolerance in society. Durga Puja is celebrated in village after village. People participate; through cultural events, dancing and other activities, it brings together every section of society, women and men alike. It counteracts the hatred spread, in my view, by Vidyapati festivals, the

Sahitya Akademi and its funded institutions, and goes further by fostering harmony. This information is for those organisers of Vidyapati festivals who strut about declaring that other castes should celebrate their own heroes if they have the capacity. Let me also make clear that the portrait of Vidyapati circulated by these institutions is itself incorrect. Moreover, they are noisily, and unsuccessfully, trying to present the Vidyapati who wrote in Avahaṭṭha and Sanskrit as the Vidyapati known as the 'cuckoo-voiced poet' (*Kavikokila*).

Does that mean there is darkness everywhere?

How Are We to Become Human Amid Hissing Snakes?

102. *Shekhar Prasang*, *O Din O Pal* and *Eho Chhali Sineh*

Abstract

Shekhar Prasang is a book based on her research on Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary. O Din O Pal came close to being an autobiography but remained a collection of reminiscences. Ego Chhali Sineh is a story collection, some of whose stories surprised me...

Keywords: Shekhar Prasang; O Din O Pal; Eho Chhali Sineh; memoir; memory; character; intimate prose

Shekhar Prasang is a book based on her research on Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary. *O Din O Pal* came close to being an autobiography but remained a collection of reminiscences. *Ego Chhali Sineh* is a story collection, some of whose stories surprised me.

Shekhar Prasang

Shekhar Prasang is based on her research on the celebrated editor Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary. Its first chapter deals with his personality and achievements, the second examines his writings, the third discusses his Hindi works, and the fourth gives the conclusion.

In the book's concluding chapter, a passage relates how Udaychandra Jha 'Vinod' went to the office of *Mithila Mihir* to meet him but found him absorbed in writing with his left hand. He would complete a piece in a single attempt, carrying out all the editing and cutting in his mind.

George Bernard Shaw thought so rapidly that he wrote in shorthand so as not to break the continuity of his thoughts, and his personal assistant would type the material out in longhand.

Mithila Mihir created an army of writers, more than a thousand strong.

O Din O Pal

This book contains twelve reminiscences.

"My Kakka: Yatriji." An incident in this reminiscence deserves mention. Premlataji cooked alongside Yatriji's eldest daughter, but Yatriji granted both a day off every week and decided that on that day his eldest son, Shobha Mishra, would cook. Premlataji writes:

"Kakka awakened in us a consciousness of our rights."

Indeed, where domestic work is still treated as unemployment or as work without remuneration, I found this delightful. Kakka is no longer with us.

But the death of one person meant the death of an entire institution. Neither those songs remain nor was the film ever made. The venture rested entirely on an individual's efforts, precariously supported by Shrikant Mandal alone. When he died, even the traces of him and his songs were erased—or allowed to disappear.

The Swedish Academy announced that this year's Nobel Prize in Literature would go to the eighty-two-year-old Annie Ernaux. Earlier, the Academy had recalled Rabindranath Tagore in a tweet.

"A butterfly counts not months but moments; thus, for it, time is nothing but time."

Annie Ernaux initially wrote autobiographical novels but soon began writing memoirs and nothing else.

Some stories by Premlata Mishra 'Prem', such as "Ego Chhali Sineh" and "Beauty Parlour," are bold, while "Shade" and "The Desolate Courtyard" show psychological insight. Yet memoir is her greatest strength, and with the treasure of experience she possesses, she can do it justice by writing memoirs, as Annie Ernaux has done. I hope many more such pieces will come from her pen.

103. A Review of Sharadindu Chaudhary

Abstract

Sharadindu Chaudhary's memoir literature [*Bat-Bat Par Bat (I–IV)*]: *Bat-Bat Par Bat, Volume 1; Marmantak-Shabdanubhuti (Bat-Bat Par Bat, Volume 2); Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh (Bat-Bat Par Bat, Volume 3); and Sakshat (Bat-Bat Par Bat, Volume 4). These four booklets collect Sharadindu Chaudhary's memoiristic essays: the first appeared in 2019, the second in 2020, and the third and fourth in 2021. His Jan Ham Janitahun, published in 2002, is likewise a collection of memoiristic essays with humour and satire. It names mainstream literary figures hungry for awards, whose exploits are such that a volume of reminiscences about them would almost automatically become a collection of humour and satire. But this is not a book of pure reminiscence: there is some added seasoning, though only a little.*

Keywords: Sharadindu Chaudhary; memoir; humour and satire; Bat-Bat Par Bat; award culture; institutions; Maithili prose

Sharadindu Chaudhary's Memoir Literature [*Bat-Bat Par Bat* (I–IV)]

Bat-Bat Par Bat, Volume 1; *Marmantak-Shabdanubhuti* (*Bat-Bat Par Bat*, Volume 2); *Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh* (*Bat-Bat Par Bat*, Volume 3); and *Sakshat* (*Bat-Bat Par Bat*, Volume 4): these four booklets are collections of Sharadindu Chaudhary's memoiristic essays. The first was published in 2019, the second in 2020, and the third and fourth in 2021.

His *Jan Ham Janitahun*, published in 2002, is also a collection of memoiristic essays incorporating humour and satire. It includes the names of mainstream literary figures hungry for awards, whose exploits are such that accounts of them almost automatically become humorous and satirical. Nevertheless, it is not a book of pure reminiscence; there is some added salt and spice, though in modest quantities. It is a matter of satisfaction that Sharadinduji apparently encountered not a single such grasping individual in the parallel literary current.

In addition, *Bar Ajagut Dekhal* (2005), *Gobar Ganesh* (2011), and *Kariya Kakkak Koramin* (2016) may be called the Kariya Kakka satire series, because in all three books Kariya Kakka appears in a role reminiscent of Khattar Kakka. Yet he is absent from a few pieces even here—for instance, "Tavat Kal," "Golaisi—Arthat," and "CD Samiksha" in *Gobar Ganesh*. All three volumes, too, rest broadly on reminiscence, but with much stronger seasoning. In the author's note to *Kariya Kakkak Koramin*, Chaudhary writes that Kariya Kakka "did whatever occurred to him, but

certainly took care that... no accusation of obscenity should arise." Yet in "CD Samiksha," published in *Gobar Ganesh* five years earlier, the author writes of Vidyanath Jha 'Vidit', chairman of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili advisory committee, selected by the so-called literary associations: "...He himself is a connoisseur of pleasures. He will perform his evening devotions with Pravasiji and a duet with Thakurain..." Another essay in the same volume, "Tavat Kal," says, "The Sahitya Akademi tried a similar experiment: even someone who owns a hotel can become a member of the advisory committee." The account in "Tavat Kal" is not obscene, but the description in "CD Samiksha" plainly is. It is evident to me that all the chairpersons selected by these supposedly literary associations for the Akademi's Maithili advisory committee have worked to bring Maithili low. But why should one of them suddenly become a paragon of truth simply because she is a woman? The sexist comment instead reveals a lack of sensitivity, among writers and editors in literature and public life, towards women and people of genders other than male. This insensitivity is also visible in "Sarkarak Linga Pariksha" ("The Government's Gender Examination") in *Kariya Kakkak Koramin*, where "a government endowed with feminine qualities" is used of Vinod Kumar Jha [see "Irshya Dvesh Nahi—Samanvay Chahi" in *Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh* (*Bat-Bat Par Bat*, Volume 3): "Sarkar" means Vinod Kumar Jha, now styled *Kavi Samrat*, emperor of poets].

1

Bat-Bat Par Bat, Volume 1

2

3

4

Sakshat (*Bat-Bat Par Bat*, Volume 4)

1

Now, Operation Sahitya Akademi

2

An Appeal

3

This Man Too Is Extraordinary

Supporting artist—vacant.

4

Watching a Film Shoot

Final presenter—Gunjanji.

5
The Health-Protection Award

6
Thanks to Laluji That Today...

7
The Editor's Name...

A Letter from Fachandi Mishra

8
Monologue

9
The Husband of a Respectable White-Collar Person

10

Jan Ham Janitahun

11
1

Bar Ajagut Dekhal...

Why Are You Troubling Your Head?

Appearance and Discernment

"...But Senior to Him..."

2

Gobar Ganesh

Meanwhile

Golaisi—"That Is to Say"

A Review of a CD

3

Kariya Kakkak Koramin

A Classification of the Granaries of Intellect

The 'Government's' Gender Examination

The Art of Writing Satire

A Child in the Lap, an Uproar in the City

The Results of Award Science

104. A Review of Nachiketa

Abstract

Poetry differs from prose in that, through imagery, it can say more in fewer words. Poetry therefore cannot be regarded as a substitute for prose adopted because there is not enough time, although such instances too may be found. Whether verse follows metre or dispenses with metre and rhythm, quality will invariably give it the power to move its readers.

Keywords: Nachiketa; Poetry; Drama; Language; Word; Text; Creative Experiment

Nachiketa's Second Person Singular

Poetry differs from prose in that images allow it to say more in fewer words. Poetry therefore cannot be regarded simply as a substitute for prose undertaken for want of time, although examples of that too may be found. Whether a poem is metrical or without metre and rhythm, if it possesses quality it will certainly make an impression.

People resort to the Left or the Right to protect their land from the ceiling laws. But when literature itself falls under a ceiling, appeals to Left or Right, insistence on or rejection of metre and rhythm, merely extend factional manoeuvring. Against this background stands Nachiketa's collection of thirty-three poems, Madhyam Purush Ekvachan (Second Person Singular).

In “In Defiance of the Sea,” the poet speaks of the sea between you and me, upon whose shore someone is weeping over its consequences; between us are shoals of fish and flocks of kites, while Varuna grasps the crests of the tides, wondering whether to allow love or the sea to triumph. As the poet speaks again of Varuna's hold upon the tide's crest, the image comes vividly before us.

In “A Particular Season on Earth,” there is a special season of love, at whose beginning even the raindrops of the monsoon start drying up. A net is cast for words, and words surrender in the renunciation of poetry. Then comes a return to the riverbank, to the recitation of a morning mantra that turns water into sky. The rain god of a barren land can make even the heavens weep without measure. Ghosts dance, beating their sticks, while a young prince dreams of communism, blowing a balloon into the sky. There is compromise with words, and every sigh drowns in the scream of language. Then comes an appeal to the sky: cry aloud, so that the sound of the thunderbolt makes us believe that the monsoon has arrived upon earth. And there is the longing to touch the drops falling on the forehead

and to read the lines one has written. The task he left unfinished last time. This, precisely, is that particular season: remembering her.

In "You," words stammer as they enter the sentence; there are the clasping of heated hands, my blazing fire, the "I" and "you" within it, a branch of the wish-fulfilling tree, and everything else reduced to emptiness or some old grandmother's tale. And while the ten directions ripen within it, there is a bewildered path—confusion! There is the long watch of nine months of pride, of pregnancy. A fifth season (!), a sixth enemy (!), a raga in the slow tempo, a fast beat (terrified), and the sun setting.

In "The Story of Night and Day," the Buddha leaves his house while the world sleeps; the poet, however, journeys into the poem, beyond the legally contracted institution of marriage and the pain of childbirth. Within the poem are knots broken free of metre and letters, exposed stitches, needlework, drops falling into the innermost being, and the attempt of a coarse, soiled cloth to cover my body—an instability rising from within—unused, amid tales of hunger, pain and separation. Sexuality goes on touching the act of seeing one stand up, becoming all thirty-six richly seasoned dishes in your kitchen. Yet my doubt is only a search within the poem, fully possessed of double meanings; its fine reasoning has dissolved into rhythm and beat. The body is stuffed with Prakrit and liver, weighed down with an awareness of the great womb and phallus. This is the only way I have learned: to dream of you every moment. And when the world awakens, I shall sleep with you: O my poem, the dark night is sure to come; take away pain and separation, hunger and fear. Just now a ray of dawn has flashed, like hope born of longing.

In "The End of the Cycle," the temper of letters floating through the sky carries a bitter stream of wavering fire; no one will hold the poet guilty for it. It is the end of the world's revolving cycle. There is no hope that metre will come to him; nor can his poetry, arrayed as before, turn into words and rain down.

In "Advice to Damayanti," people struck by arrows lie petrified (!). They are limbless, helpless people. Grass and leaves hold them fast, while Takshaka is entangled and concealed in the silk-cotton tree. There is swaying in the wind and the smouldering of fire in a gust. Damayanti, Damayanti: the silent forest. Among flowers and leaves is an orphaned sun (!); Hiranya's belly is cautiously slit open, and the thirty-three ugly mouths counsel the trees to go this way. Damayanti, do not cross the forest. In the darkness, traffickers in bodies wait in the north-eastern quarter. Damayanti, the time has come. Nala is hidden in the south-western corner. The trees know how a poem arrives. They know history, and man's cruelty. They know how the great forest was thoughtlessly laid waste and destroyed. Domesticated (!) trees have forgotten their language. They warn

Damayanti: do not trust human beings; they will bind you with stories, poems and rumours. Do not cross the forest. If she does not, all the trees will write their first poem about Damayanti.

In "Questionnaire," the questions tumble forth: Is this the immovable final night? Is this the last line of the song? Can you read my poetry? Is this my last day? Is there now compulsion to do something (!), a body bewildered, some destitution suddenly felt? Was it borne in sleep? What is the destiny of my letters? The restless, hovering bee of the mind, like a current of deathless love.

In "Words Growing Within," the sound of words is like somebody weeping inside a cave. Or like laughter from a mountain summit. There is the stealthy approach of footsteps, the sound of an envelope being opened. Words bubble up from every line of a letter. And a sister's flowing tears are understood only belatedly. Sentences collapse; they cannot form either a remainder or a compound. One barely understands the cracking of a broken backbone, yet the hardened poet is dragged by the throat. Within poetry, things heard, sensed and understood appear nonetheless as intimations. These words emerge from the poet's own depths, but even he has no right to alter them. He has only the right to the kiss, to love's union. He has no right to churn and bind them, nor to hatred or anger. He may, however, decorate them with flowers and leaves, or weave a braid through the watches of night. He may brighten the parting of the hair with the first sun's redness, place a necklace at the throat, wrap warm tree-bark about the body of words, and thus honour facts that have happened to that body. The poet dedicates this poem to the poet Ilarani Singh.

In "Known and Familiar," the body is read page after page, until life itself begins to feel known and familiar. There are songs of layers and depths and the poet's own confession that her trust in his words will fall away. And there is only the language of touch: a rural experience whose etymology nobody can supply, but which one lives.

In "Synonymous Word," the poet suspects that he cannot speak of a dream, for to do so would be to recite all your names. There is neither weakness in the verbal root nor any shortage of prefixes and suffixes. Otherwise he could have uttered an equivalent word—its language is that of an inaudible philosophy gone off with the hoofbeats of a horse. For this a new Amarakosha and a new poem would have to be written.

In "Sprout," four seeds of poetry germinate in the mind, and words of love are inscribed within them. Do not entangle them in questions whose answers even I do not know. Listening to this talk, one finds a treasury of words distributed to four poets all at once. Yet the four will sing together, and the sprout of love will grow.

In "After So Many Years," the speaker stands in your courtyard and asks to be allowed to read a poem; in childhood you had driven him away, fining him (!) for breaking the metre. Among the other presences was a sorrowful mother, without the means for Chhath worship, with grain for only four months of the year; roasted, unsalted sweet potatoes were her salvation. Let me read you a poem.

In "Why Do You Not Write?" there is a full stop. Not another line in your name. Why persist in writing a love letter at all, using letters invented by somebody else? One may overlay them with colour, meaning, clothing and longing. There is the language of dry lips and fingers playing on the soles of feet, of extraordinary inland-letter words and their arrangement. And then there is the reproach of not writing a letter.

In "Rajhans," the royal swan of poetry has moved two steps away from your body. Meteor showers and other disturbances have left it no leisure. Nor has your body yet been put to its use. I shall ask the swan to fly with you once. For as long as it can bear your weight. The poet's simile of a teardrop lies hidden beneath the edge of the sari, by the soles of the feet; he will ask the royal swan to lay aside the curiosity that has become a young woman.

In "Darkness," a bird says: reveal nothing confidential, or darkness will descend. Last night poetry came for a watch of the night and disappeared into the crowd of prose. There is a secret history, sin, the distance from love to marriage, and other such things. Why are you frightened? No one will ask your name. No one will ask; bird, tell me what you knew of the poet whose grave has only just been dug.

In "You Alone," I have called you into the poem and seen you several times. But you do not even turn to look. It is no ordinary document of love in which profit and loss are entered in a ledger. Nor is it a routine invitation or the food of common people. I have given you a name in the poem, one that the little chirping birds might pronounce. Not a name around which some sensational tale might be built. Yet you say nothing.

In "Ancient Love," the song demands its price. It asks and answers questions, though where is there room for that in nature's school? Ancient love is confined from the textbook to the history lesson. There is the examination question: use an old word in a sentence. Are all the sentences true or false? State their meaning … But I have grown clever now. I can read the anguish of the Mandakranta metre. I can measure the chastity of the pure dhaivata note. My blood has rightly recognised the savagery of life's arithmetic. I speak little, and when I do, I turn not towards the past but towards the unheard, unarrived, ghostly time. My vision advances towards

feelings neither spoken nor translated. The ridge of a banana field, the haunted cattle and the old love have left everything soiled.

In "Desire," I need something—but what am I to desire? You are infinite; free of qualifying adjectives, you will instantly fulfil my heart's wish. Before I can desire anything, the suffixes of this illusionary world take hold: my life is bound up in nominal and verbal endings, in fixed phrases, in an impoverished lexicon. I can give you the short, the very short, the syllable Om, the form of a Vedic hymn. My small desires, language, feeling and pain are irregular, while the fragrance of Yaman Kalyan is regulated.

In "For My Husband—1," a hole has appeared in your roof; the bitter cold wind has chilled the starch-water, and the tears of the sky have soaked my sweet potatoes. The bedding is wet, you are silent, and this hole will bring you to ruin. Then write the song of that destruction in your own hand.

In "For My Husband—2," he says my place is on his head, but I refuse to remain with the severed or dishevelled topknot. In his heart? I will not live beside the breathing apparatus. In his eyes? Not beside the tears beneath his spectacles. On his lips? I shall not become the beads of a prayer-rosary. On his tongue (because of the taste of cooking)? Yes, perhaps—but there must be a way out of that too. Beneath the shoes on his feet, upon the earth, I understand politics. How does a shoe rise from beneath the foot to the head? The day you understand that, you will have learned the first lesson of resistance.

In "For My Husband—3," do not ask about grammar or script. This poem! What am I to do—throw it into the fire? Do not say such things. What if I am illiterate? I am a magic wand that can be waved.

If anyone writes a poem about me, and grammar upon my consciousness, why should that be surprising? Do not call it hollow pretence! In "Accounts," Hiriya puts five words in her bag before going to work in the fields at dawn. One word is spent eating unsalted sweet potato; half a word is used when Bhusahu Babu kicks her three times as she takes shelter under a peepal tree in the rain. One and a half remain, and another one and a half are set aside for liquor bought on credit at Chuhara's shop in the Chamar settlement. The remaining words—seven times fourteen of them! —she reserves to purchase provisions in the market. By evening not a word remains to place upon Hiriya's heart; how then can she open it without words? She stands in the courtyard under the dew all night.

In "Self-Statement," let me tell you something of my mind, Kapalkundala. But the songstress has been made to stand there for the people's leader of striking weavers … The showman recites my own poetry while I wear a rope around my waist in a separate enclosure. Let us speak, then, of something other than poetry. But neither relish, nor words, nor

the force of a blow is left. I have no such name either: what a prosaic life! Let us ask something beyond the walls of prose: in which grammatical person's number is one entangled, in the forest entangled in tense and case? The ruin of indeclinables, the stripping of adjectives of their clothing, and the removal of the substantive from its throne. Is there anyone who can discern the mind's condition by seeing a prefix? In the tangled locks of constrained masculinity lies your hand, Panini. And the Maheshvara Sutras will cry aloud when I say something to you. Patanjali and Hemachandra will subdue the poet and explain the second person singular. Tvam, tvam, tvaya, tubhyam, tvat, tava, tvayi—the declensional forms of "you." Kapalkundala, from the mind onward, everything lacks rule, class or aim; and you alone remain singular in the second person.

From you comes love, from you hatred—love and hatred come from you; on the day of the last truth, hang me, and then you shall no longer hear me. Before you can bring me down, I shall cast you away. I have removed all the lamps from near you. I love you, but I hate you still more. I have put an end to eyes, hands and both lips. Even so, your smile turns false words into ice around my philosophy, and the current moves again through every vein.

In "Leave a Little Space," leave this corner free, my longing beneath the heap of letters. I myself had written it, to make a poem about you! I need space, for the poet has three legs: one covered in beastliness, another with ink dried upon its tip, and the third a counterfeit heart. If you want a poet like me, leave a little room.

In "Fear—1," there is the Atharvan poet. What if the book is stolen? Then perhaps the poem will survive under another person's name while the poet disappears from history.

It costs money to keep me alive and trouble to arrange my funeral pyre (I adorned it with profound mantras); how much history will have to be written upon my poetry in anger! In "Fear—2," the ability to deceive has arrived: I now fear no one. For I have learned the arts of floating and becoming the very lowest! Will an inaudible word awaken the rabbit and owl, and the touch of an untouchable girl awaken hunger? I have learned the art of perishing! I am no longer toothless; a pair of teeth has appeared! Hard words, cool breasts, vast sentences, tender compositions, fearsome commentaries and scattered texts, overwhelmed by meaning and meaninglessness.

In "Naming," call the moon chandrama and the stars a nebula, and the very meaning of night changes! Call light pratyusha and the sun martanda, and the eyes are dazzled. Call a forest a pleasure-grove and grass durva and akshata, and the mantra seems to recite itself. Call ceaseless toil

tireless effort and the joining of two unlike words a compound, and the broken heart cools! Life belongs only to the living, and only to you and me, who survive by changing our forms, trusting the changing horoscope of each lunar day and the calculations of fate. Call me Dushyanta and you Shakuntala, and concern for Kanva and the fawn arises at once.

In "Today's Poet, a Very Undisciplined Poet," bound and dragged by the rope of metre and non-metre, trapped, wounded and rubbed raw, dwell and burn in the spice of ornamentation, heating and covering, but do not leap across mountains or roar. Keep singing the dhaivata note. Poet! Become your own line and go beyond it, to the threshold of poets. The poets are coming—kavih, kavi, kavayah—to a modern tune. Critics who will make poetry metrical, fettered and venerated through their thought. They will let poetry remain half-poetry and half-non-poetry, upon the half-woman, half-man Ardhanarishvara.

How unruly is this poet of today, this Hatnarishvara! In "You Said Nothing," you have said nothing to this day; you have buried a treasury of words beneath the earth. But corpses are what we bury beneath the ground. Yet I am a Hindu enthusiast intoxicated with religion: even in death I shall not go underground; I shall burn, blaze and chant my song in the flames. Nails and hair will disappear; which discipline or scripture has taught us to bridle feeling? Let the body remain covered beneath pride and figures of speech; lock the throat so that no sound can emerge. But I am a Rajput of the solar dynasty; my weapons are word, meaning, voice and script. If defeated in debate, I shall surrender! But whether I win or lose, I shall certainly speak. The apparatus of light lies restless; the red, green and yellow signals are mute. I glimpse your plan: to strip away clothing and weapons, to speak falsehood through half-truths, to sit in the row and steal the nectar; life, a corpse of words, is at stake in this game of signs! Yet I still hope you will say something, or at least begin to sing one of my songs.

In "Recite Your Poem!" you have taken your old lover—that is, me—to that new house on the summit! I shall ask the clouds the way there, and they will smile crookedly at the sight of us together! Yet neither clouds, nor stars, nor zodiac, horoscope or heavenly geometry, nor any mistake in fate's arithmetic caused that separation; together they conspired to bring it about! Our last meeting took place in a hollow of the moon. Neither the stones nor the geography of darkness were to blame. The signs of sun and earth, the stars' signatures, all conspired to bring about separation. So that neither of us could utter a single memorable line or word. Silence strangled our throats. Yet the fault was neither silence's nor the inscription on the wall, whose alien letters we had never learned to read. The hollow filled with your poems, their lines rising upward, while our attempt to climb their summit failed. I do not blame those lines. You alone have no

monopoly on betrayal. I have now learned your language, to climb the mountain ablaze with longing, to read every line, poem and inscription! I have learned to read your signature. But in this inscription you are showing me measurements of foundations, timber, sand and cement, doors, hinges and floors! I want instead to hear a few poems from you, in your language, which is now mine as well.

In "Biography," should there be the mutiny of the cantonments, Tantia Tope, Victoria, the birth of the government poet Rabindranath and discussions of widow remarriage? Has an insect eaten a whole page of the first issue of the theatre journal Hera Shim Lebedev? But for the custodians of today's theatre it scarcely matters whether the page can be found. On the reverse is an essay on Michael Madhusudan and the beginnings of modern poetry; but how would a poet who learned nothing after 1990 know that! And so he does not fit the shape-shifters like me. And 1951: the birth of a government poet of this century, his impoverished childhood, the neglect he suffered, false tales of Vivekananda and terse sayings? Must Girish Ghosh, Sir Ashutosh, Netaji's escape and the Mahatma's imprisonment precede my story? Falsehood! For does history begin only after Godse's appearance and my birth? Then come the shattered geography, the arithmetic of appropriation, orthodox caste divisions, and the crown of "Vedana." Set the heart right? You, my official biographer, would like every chapter to begin in 1951. My stepmother and the matriarch of the family. Fabricated tales of Grandmother, transformed into the princess of Sonbarsa. How did poetry enter, and what woman entered my life? I am abandoning the tale: look for somebody else. Some unborn, unknown and unnamed poet.

Until then poetry herself will care for me and narrate my life! In "Second Person Singular," the command is to think of somebody other than you! But trees and flowers, stones and treacherous grammar have spread their snares! You yourself are the second person singular! Politics, mountains of national debt, corrupt appointments … you are the second person singular, yet … write Navya-Nyaya's injustice, pile up Vaisheshika categories, forget the grammar of wealth; you are the second person singular, yet … the aesthetic essence of erotic feeling and suggestion is futile, merely momentary. From a life reaching to Jatayu, to saving somebody else's Sita, Gita. Chalati, chalatah, chalanti—poetry flowing like a stream of true speech, with grammar in the second person singular: you are there, yet … how could I think of anything other than you?

Poetry: People read little poetry. The efforts to propagate a language such as Sanskrit employ simplified Sanskrit in conversational workshops. Fiction and novels are translated into Sanskrit from modern languages, but poetry is excluded from that process. The reason is that no one reads poetry, and the translation of poems into a language that needs camps to teach its use is deemed a waste of energy. The position of Maithili has become somewhat similar: if the villages disappeared today, the number of people speaking the language would shrink drastically. People would speak Maithili only at seminars and literary gatherings. The need for camps even to teach Maithili pronunciation is already being felt. What, then, is the need or justification for writing poetry in Maithili? Emphasising that one writes poems because there is too little time merely brings the horror of the situation into sharper focus. Under such conditions, events in the neighbourhood, personal ambitions, allegations and accounts of journeys have become the subject matter of Maithili poetry. But why not use prose for these things? Stories are dramatised for the stage, but to what purpose is prose converted into poetry? The readers of these hastily written poems are partisan reviewers and those "great poets" who transform prose into verse and write glowing reviews of their own poetry in their prefaces! Who will recognise the worth of poetic creation? Personal, worldly experience that does not reach sufficient depth cannot become distinguished poetry, even if it rhymes. However abstract metaphysical reflection may be, unless it joins the world of lived experience it cannot stir us either, even if it is unrhymed or carries the banner of a faction or an ideology. Human beings first need food, clothing and shelter, and only then metaphysical contemplation. The Buddha asks whether all those participating in festivities know that death is inevitable; if they do, how can they continue to celebrate? Similarly, when the modern Maithili poet sees the linguistic, cultural and economic ground disappearing from beneath his feet and yet shuts his eyes to that truth, his attempt to force ideological commentary about events at home and abroad into verse lacks force. Even when he writes, as a supposed favour, about

the indigenous Dalit community, intending to help it, his poetry acquires no cutting edge. But when Rajdev Mandal writes poetry—

...

Drop by drop, from the dripping blood,
The earth is being bathed;
A bird asks
This question of its own heart:
Will the dark and heavy night ahead
Leave our kind alive ...?

That sends a shudder through us. The poet's caste, the caste of that bird—or what? What need has this poem of factional bargaining or a self-absorbed preface? What party manoeuvring or ideological banner does such feeling require? Poetry needs excellence. It needs a foundation in language and culture. It does not merely need imported subject matter introduced in a patronising spirit. Nor does it need imported sensibility that amounts to a superficial, condescending attempt to search for the linguistic, cultural and economic foundation vanishing under its own feet. A good poem may be written on any subject: on the Buddha's concern for humanity's future, or to lend strength to an unsettled mind—otherwise people will keep going to hypocritical holy men for sermons. It may address society's linguistic, cultural and economic basis—otherwise camps will have to be organised to teach Maithili itself. Imagery must also communicate; otherwise one must first construct an atmosphere around the poet, arrange a stage for his poems, and hold training camps in his vocabulary and ideology. Some poets are already doing precisely that! The soft rises and falls of Mithila's speech, the manifold strengths of its working people, and also the region's cultural and social rigidities, its politics, daily life, social norms, economic conditions, morals, religion and philosophy—all must find a place in literature. Without these, literature will become one-sided, topple over, and be fit only to frame and hang on a wall. To create poetry is a literary necessity. The day it becomes necessary to hold camps to teach the people of Mithila the Maithili language, the very existence of poetry can be questioned. Poets must remain vigilant so that such a day never comes. Against this background, tvam, tvam, tvaya, tubhyam, tvat, tava, tvayi—Nachiketa's second person singular—appears in contrast to aham, mam, maya, mahyam, mat, mama, mayi, the forms of the first person singular.

The poet himself, in collaboration with Rizio Yohannan Raj, translated this book into English under the title Second Person Singular. Although the poet wrote no preface to the Maithili book, he did write one for the English translation. A Maithili rendering of that preface is given below. Both the Maithili and English editions contain line drawings between the poems, but, with a few exceptions, the drawings differ between the two

editions, and the positions of some have changed, even though the artist is the same, Sanjay Bhattacharya. The poem "Shuchita-Sucharitasu" has not been translated into English. The pseudonym "Nachiketa" has also been removed from the poet's name in the English translation.

By Way of Introduction

I

Whenever I speak or write in a pluralistic environment such as India's, someone in the audience wants to know: who is speaking? Please explain.

When one plays several roles in a multilingual setting, one must draw a terminological line of demarcation. Yet my instinct as a grammarian sometimes defeats the poet within me. I realise that, if given the opportunity, readers of this slim book might wish to part company with the grammarian. I remember verbal battles with my grandfather over what was correct and incorrect and how words could best be used. Exasperated, he would say, "Never get in the grammarian's way!" Whenever I asked him why, he would recite an old saying in unadulterated Maithili, which means:

"Fall in love with a grammarian and all your letters will be painted red with mistakes; quarrel with him and you will get your verb forms wrong; argue with him and you will forget every demonstrative adjective; kill a grammarian and his ghost will hang around with weak verbs; abuse him and a tree of tautologies will spring up. You cannot overpower him. So if you encounter a grammarian and a snake, kill the grammarian first. Kill him under any circumstances!"

Whatever one may say about making grammar and linguistics a profession, there is no doubt that deictic expressions—words or phrases whose meaning is not clear without a context—anaphoric expressions, by which an earlier word gives its meaning to a later one, and the inflections of words for person, number and gender, remain indispensable to translators and bilingual speakers. Location and discourse style remain important too (Homi Bhabha, The Location of Culture, New York: Routledge, 1994), since the abundance or poverty of a person's discourse helps determine where that person is situated. Who could understand this better than a writer in a marginalised language such as Maithili? Beginning in the thirteenth century, the language witnessed the unforgettable songs of Vidyapati, Lochandas and Chanda Jha, and the immensely popular plays of Umapati and some thirty other dramatists. Yet in recent times it has not produced many poets or novelists capable of acquiring readers in other linguistic and cultural spaces. Poets such as Nagarjun (Yatri) and Rajkamal Chaudhary, and writers such as

Harimohan Jha and Lily Ray, have been translated into other Indian languages, but attempts to reach an international readership remain exceedingly limited.

It is true that fashionable theories such as Western postmodernism have made their appearance on a smaller scale: the fragmentation of ideals and the heterogeneity of signifiers, with the consequent fragmentation of social processes, have appeared in Maithili literature as in other modern Indian languages. These trends have given rise to explanations that account for actual and perceived social problems only partially or relatively, not in their entirety. They certainly carry us towards a point where place and worldliness become emptied of context. But even today, when I discuss dynamic verbs and the postpositions that lead from here to there, location and deictic words and phrases—expressions that cannot be understood without context—remain important to me as a writer.

What my poetry says will place the distinction of grammatical person at the centre. This does not mean that my concern for gender and number is any less, as many of the poems here demonstrate; these concepts are invaluable in translation, interpretation and the conceptual worlds of others. It is another matter that some of us may feel that many basic technical terms have lost their context. For the poet and the person he addresses, however, the "second person singular" will always remain a real Other.

At this point I feel I should set out my own position in the debate between "I" and "he," so that my readers may understand the background of a multicultural writer. I write poetry and drama mainly in Maithili, spoken in northern Bihar and Nepal's Tarai, and I also write literary essays, serious poetry and songs in Bangla. I have written essays in Hindi as well. My English writing chiefly concerns literature and literary translation. I inhabit several languages because of my background: my mother came from Mymensingh in Bangladesh, and my wife, Manaka, is a Bangla speaker from Kolkata, while my father was a native Maithili speaker and an author and editor in that language. Both my parents taught Hindi literature at university, giving us opportunities to meet many important writers of Hindi and Maithili literature in our home. In addition, my education was in Bangla through school and exclusively in English at college and university. This multilingual background defined my literary inclination. Several volumes of my Maithili poetry and eleven plays have been published. The present collection is a translation of my Maithili poetry collection Madhyam Purush Ekvachan, published in 2005.

In Bangla I have published a poetry collection, a book of children's verse and a collection of edited literary essays. As a literary translator, my most satisfying work has been Anukriti (1999), a Bangla translation of

outstanding Maithili poems written since 1950, as well as a volume of Rabindranath's children's literature published in 1997. My journey from Maithili to Bangla to English, with a few steps through Hindi along the way, has enriched both the subject matter and form of my writing. I write on different subjects in different languages, and beyond poetry I work in different genres: drama in Maithili, literary criticism in Bangla, essays on translation in English and the sociology of language in Hindi.

II

Thus, broadly speaking, I perform three fundamental kinds of work, and this is how I should like to regard myself: an insignificant writer, producing everything from poetry to essays; a translator (not a very good one, though I do not know how others would rank me), moving between several languages, mainly English, Maithili, Bangla and Hindi, in that order; and a linguist specialising in both the structural and social aspects of language. These are, in a way, the roles of reader, teacher and employer.

As a writer, my earliest work seems to have involved concealing my identity. Whenever I write in any of these languages, I try to erase the signs that disclose my professional identity or my plural existence—even my age and bodily marks that might betray my taste in dress. Some signs may still remain visible or detectable. It is no wonder, then, that I adopted a pen name in Maithili. I have known writers who present themselves as somebody or something else, and I am sure we all have stories about writers whose game is to turn themselves into another. There are many ways of playing it. Some define their position through camouflage. Others trim the boundaries of the frame into which the text must fit. Some try to hide the pair of eyes—the eyes of a supporter or the familiar "I" of a poem or narrative—through which the reader is invited to watch events unfold. Others make public pronouncements, declaring contemporary or earlier writers worthless, or ridicule all critics and academic criticism. To me, it is a game everyone plays. Some play openly; others conceal their manoeuvres in various ways. My answer as a writer has been to push my "I" into the background and place the social interpretation of feelings, relationships and their friction at the centre. Put differently, it is the conversion of my personal ending from the first person singular to the third person singular in order to address "you"—my second person singular.

As a translator, however, I wish to put myself at the centre; I try to occupy the front seat, and I do. Textbook accounts of translation teach us to maintain a secondary presence so that the original author may be brought into relief through the process we undertake. Yet as a practitioner of that process I behave as an equal: taking liberties when there is a justification for them, stitching or repairing what needs attention, and adding patches beneath carefully chosen fabric when I cannot leave them undone. People

much more learned than I, engaged in this activity, have continually warned me that I am at best merely the recipient of a text, a participant in the author's conversation. I am told I must let the author, whose voice may be muffled by my conspicuous or well-intentioned interventions, make the magnificent presence of the first person felt through every word, the voices of the text's characters and every turn the text takes.

It is true that an author converses with readers through a text, establishing a kind of paired relation between first and second persons. But when I entered the world of translation, I was told I had no right to interrupt the author or his intentions, for I was merely a reader. Unfortunately, even as readers we are hurt by decisions authors take; once we enter a text and a character becomes our own, we grow impatient with that character's misfortunes. It is hardly surprising, therefore, that readers question the author's knowledge of time and place, education, background and scholarship on account of those decisions. At the moment of creation, when the reader abandons a passive position and assumes an active creative role as translator-interpreter, I see considerable scope for a translator to become more than a passive sounding board, and to go beyond merely reporting events. This, I think, is a quiet revolution that has occurred in several important works of translation over time. This is what I should like to see as a transformation from the second person to the first.

As a linguist, I have worked in linguistic situations about which I knew little beforehand—Ladakhi, Adi and even Telugu. Most of my work, however, has concerned languages I know well, and in some projects my intuitive knowledge as a native speaker has played the leading role in deciding which available solution is best. Whenever I worked on Bangla, Maithili and Hindi, all three of which I acquired naturally, the greatest challenge posed by the classical school of linguistics was that I should first forget that I knew those languages. I was told to set aside my personal relativity and look at my languages objectively, even with a kind of anxiety. Becoming an Other as a linguist was considered essential, because utterance after utterance that might appear meaningless could, in certain circumstances, become a possible utterance. Although this may sound absurd, we were trained to work with natural languages, and I recognise a remarkable judgement in which truth prevails and falsehood is defeated. If my linguistic intuition sifts utterances from another cultural location, within a structural or poetic frame or an act of creation, the person changes from third to first.

Thus, whichever role I take, my personal endings change through certain transformations. I understand and believe that when I translate even my own poetry, translation continues the violence done to the original language and text: the whole undertaking may seem a rebellion against

grammar, yet every resulting text becomes the product of the rules of another grammar. Eric Cheyfitz, in The Poetics of Imperialism (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1997), argues that translation, as a rule, performs a violent surgery upon the original text it transforms, because it attempts to restate the thought embedded in that text in a significantly different, never wholly equivalent form. When one culture translates another, therefore, the original is altered.

I do not know how far these transformations will please the readers of this book. Katha, a major organisation working to build bridges between languages, surely understands these matters. I find reassurance in recalling that my artist friend Sanjay Bhattacharya, having read these poems both in the original and in translation, spent several weeks in his studio producing attractive drawings that also make the book a memorable visual experience.

Uday Narayan Singh
August 2006

The title Second Person Singular has become popular in world literature as well. Formerly English distinguished thou (second person singular) from you (second person plural), but now you serves both singular and plural.

Sayed Kashua is an Arab-Israeli novelist. His Hebrew novel appeared in 2010 and was translated into English by Mitch Ginsburg in 2012 as Second Person Singular. The novel has two plots that eventually converge.

Both plots concern Hebrew-speaking Arab Israelis living in Israel.

The first follows a lawyer in West Jerusalem who buys an old copy of Tolstoy's The Kreutzer Sonata (named after Beethoven's sonata of the same name). The narrator of The Kreutzer Sonata tells fellow passengers on a train how, driven by jealousy over his wife's suspected affair with a violinist, he killed her; she and the violinist used to perform Beethoven's Kreutzer Sonata together. Tolstoy's book was banned at the time. The lawyer's wife had mentioned it, since the work had often been discussed in lectures on Freud's psychology. Inside the copy, the lawyer finds an Arabic note written in his wife's hand, resembling a love letter. On its first page appears the name of a former owner, Yonatan. Abandoning his other affairs, he begins to search for Yonatan.

The second plot concerns Amir, a social worker. He goes dancing with a new trainee named Leila. That night Amir leaves his job and begins caring for a Jewish man named Yonatan, who is in a persistent vegetative state and closely resembles him. Leila, meanwhile, leaves a note at Amir's office saying she enjoyed their dance and asking him to telephone her. Amir

enrolls in an art school in Yonatan's name and, after Yonatan dies, assumes his identity.

When the lawyer finally finds Amir, he discovers that Leila is the lawyer's own wife. Both Amir and Leila say that their dance took place before Leila met the lawyer. The lawyer is satisfied. But in the novel's postscript, when he later visits an exhibition of art-school graduates, he sees a nude painting by Amir, now living as Yonatan, that is the very image of Leila!

Nachiketa's Second Person Singular comes to us through tvam, tvam, tvaya, tubhyam, tvat, tava and tvayi—the Sanskrit cases of "you"—in contrast to aham, mam, maya, mahyam, mat, mama and mayi, the forms of "I."

A diversity of images is the lifeblood of poetry. A poem deserves to be written only when meaning emerges from word after word; for a commentary upon words, after all, there is already the genre of prose.

In "In Defiance of the Sea," the sea lies between you and me, and Varuna holds the crests of the tides, wondering whether to allow love or the sea to win. He remains deep in thought: there is no final decision. Both possibilities appear valid, yet only one can prevail, and the power of choice lies in his hold upon the tide's crest. In "A Particular Season on Earth," there is a net cast for words, there is surrender, and this is poetry—and renunciation? Water becomes sky. The sky is an image; what is sky? Infinite and of one colour. If it is water, then water must surely become sky too. There is the rain god of a barren land; if raindrops fell, why would the land be barren? This god is surely not born—yet he is a rain god who can make even the sky weep without limit! There is compromise with words, and only then can the work proceed. To compromise with words is also to compromise with meaning; the work itself then becomes relative. A play of meanings results from a play of words. In "You," sentences stammer, hands are clasped while still hot. Since the previous poem has compromised meaning, the sentence must surely stammer, for sentences are made of words. In "The Story of Night and Day," the Buddha leaves his home while the world sleeps, but the poet, by contrast, sets out into the poem. In "The End of the Cycle," letters float through the sky and stir a stream of fire. Letters make words, and words make sentences. It is letters, not clarified butter, that fan the fire; words compromise, sentences stammer. In "Advice to Damayanti," even the trees know how poetry arrives. Damayanti … do not cross the forest. If she does not, all the trees will write their first poem about her. Letters, words and sentences ignite, compromise and stammer … If Damayanti crosses the forest, all the trees will write their first poem about her, for they know how poetry comes into being. In "Questionnaire," the speaker asks, "Can you read my poem?" and "Is this my last day?" Having become a poem, it now needs someone to

read it, and the means and desire to read it. In "Words Growing Within," the sentence that earlier stammered now collapses. Heard, felt and understood things enter the poem, even if only as intimations. The poet dedicates this poem to the poet Ilarani Singh.

In "Known and Familiar," the body is read page by page and life begins to seem known and familiar. Normally pages are written one after another; here life itself advances page by page, and the farther it advances the more familiar it seems. In "Synonymous Word," a new Amarakosha and a new poem must be written: a new vocabulary for a new poem, first a collection of the words, then the poem. In "Sprout," four seeds of poetry grow in the mind, and the treasury of words has been distributed among four poets at once. Poetry is a game of words! In "After So Many Years," the speaker was chased away in childhood for breaking metre. Now grown up, with so many years elapsed, he still asks to be permitted to read a poem. In "Why Do You Not Write?" why this stubborn insistence upon writing a love letter? Its letters were invented by someone else, and colour, meaning, clothing and longing merely laid over them. What an empty insistence! In "Rajhans," there is poetry's royal swan: "I shall ask it to fly with you once." In "Darkness," poetry came last night and disappeared into the crowd of prose. In "You Alone," "I have given you a name in the poem, one a little bird could pronounce," yet you say nothing. In "Ancient Love," the speaker can read the anguish of the Mandakranta metre, measure the fidelity of the pure dhaivata note, and recognise in his blood the barbarity of life's arithmetic. In "Desire," what is there that I want, and what am I to desire? I can offer the short and very short syllables, Om, and the shape of a Vedic hymn. In "For My Husband—1," the sky's tears have soaked my sweet potatoes. In "For My Husband—2," how does a shoe rise from beneath the foot to the head? Understanding that is the first lesson of resistance. In "For My Husband—3," why be surprised if somebody writes poetry about me, and grammar upon my mind? In "Accounts," Hiriya puts five words into her bag as she leaves for fieldwork at dawn. By evening none remains to place upon her heart; without words, how can she open that heart?

In "Self-Statement," the showman recites my poem while I wear a rope around my waist in another enclosure. What a prosaic life! Patanjali and Hemachandra suppress the poet and explain the second person singular: directionless, you alone in the second person singular. In "From You Love, from You Hatred," I love you, but hate you even more. In "Leave a Little Space," space is needed because the poet has three legs: one covered with animality, another tipped with dried ink, the third a counterfeit heart. If you want a poet like me, leave me a little room. In "Fear—1," it costs money to keep me alive and trouble to arrange my pyre! In "Fear—2," the art of deception has arrived. I am no longer toothless: a pair of teeth has

grown! In "Naming," call a forest a grove and grass durva and akshata, and the mantra recites itself. If my name is Dushyanta and yours Shakuntala, concern for Kanva and the fawn follows automatically. Nature and character are born through names, through words. In "Today's Poet, a Very Undisciplined Poet," the poets are coming—kavih, kavi, kavayah—to a modern tune, those who would make poetry metrical, fettered and venerated. In "You Said Nothing," even in death I shall not go under the earth: I shall burn and sing my song in the flames. I am a solar-dynasty Rajput, and my weapons are word, meaning, voice and script. In "Recite Your Poem!" you took your old lover, meaning me, to that new house on the summit. Our last meeting was in a hollow of the moon. Yet I want to hear a few poems in your language, which is now mine as well. In "Biography," has an insect eaten the whole first page of the account of the theatre and Herasim Lebedeff? Does history begin only with the appearance of Godse and my birth? There is some unborn, unknown, unnamed poet; until then poetry herself will look after me and tell my life story. "Second Person Singular" is the second title-bearing poem in the collection; in the earlier poem, the phrase appeared within the poem rather than as its title. Mountains of national debt, corrupt appointments ... write of Navya-Nyaya and injustice, pile up Vaisheshika categories, forget the grammar of wealth: you yourself are the second person singular, yet ...

Thus the second person singular arrives in company with a multitude of images.

The second person singular is the person—male or female—who is addressed individually. Nachiketa's Second Person Singular was composed within a postmodern society in which webs of letters and words and arrangements of sentences are fashioned, where changing a word or substituting a synonym can make the sun begin to give warmth.

Four Postmodern Plays: Samuel Beckett's French Play Waiting for Godot, Harold Pinter's English Play The Birthday Party, Badal Sircar's Bangla Play Evam Indrajit, and Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s Maithili Play No Entry: Ma Pravish

[No Entry: Ma Pravish was published in 2008 but was not selected for the Sahitya Akademi Award in 2010, 2011 or 2012. The book will now no longer be eligible for the Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili literature. There have been other instances of this kind. The place of No Entry: Ma Pravish within Maithili and world literature is examined in the following essay. This series will continue.]

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Waiting for Godot is a two-act tragicomedy. Samuel Beckett wrote it in French in 1952, and it was first performed in Paris in 1953. The English-language version was staged in London in 1955 and published in 1956.

Harold Pinter's English play The Birthday Party was staged in Cambridge in 1958 and published in 1960.

Badal Sircar's Bangla play Evam Indrajit was written in 1962 and staged in Calcutta in 1965.

Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s No Entry: Ma Pravish was published electronically in 2008 and subsequently in print that year. On 19 February 2011, this ninety-minute play was performed under Kunal's direction at Kalidas Rangalaya, Patna.

These four plays—in French, English, Bangla and Maithili—are classed as postmodern drama. Those who came away from a performance of Samuel Beckett's Waiting for Godot experienced something strange. The play has only five characters: Estragon, Vladimir, Lucky, Pozzo and a boy. At evening, beside a tree on a country road, Estragon sits on a mound, struggling to remove a boot with both hands. He becomes breathless and exhausted. He starts speaking with Vladimir, and a long, apparently pointless conversation wanders from one subject to another. Pozzo and Lucky arrive. Pozzo appears to be the master and Lucky the servant—a servant with a long rope fastened around his neck by Pozzo. Lucky enters first, followed by Pozzo holding the rope. Lucky carries a large bag, a folding stool, a picnic basket and a greatcoat. Pozzo has a whip. Lucky obeys orders. When commanded, he picks up all his burdens again and stands. Estragon and Vladimir dislike seeing him loaded down like this; when Pozzo says that Lucky is used to it, Estragon takes Pozzo for a tyrant. Estragon wipes Lucky's tears, and Lucky kicks him. Pozzo says he had warned them that Lucky dislikes strangers. And what are Estragon and Vladimir doing there? They are waiting for someone called Godot.

Pozzo and Lucky depart. A boy comes to Estragon and Vladimir and says that Godot cannot come today; he will come tomorrow. More aimless conversation follows, and the boy too leaves. The light on the stage then changes to night and the moon rises. Vladimir and Estragon resume their conversation. Even amid the apparently idle talk there are things of significance. They decide to leave, but neither moves. The curtain falls on Act One.

Act Two takes place at the same time and in the same location. Vladimir remembers everything, but Estragon has forgotten. Estragon says he forgets everything immediately or never forgets at all, although fragments do return to him. Pozzo and Lucky arrive. Pozzo is now blind; Lucky still

carries the loads. The rope is there too, but shorter. Pozzo and Lucky fall down. Pozzo cries for help, but Estragon and Vladimir continue talking.

As in the first act, Estragon calls Vladimir "Didi." Vladimir says they should not waste their time in idle chatter. At regular intervals Pozzo repeats his anguished cry for "Help!" Yet Estragon and Vladimir pay no attention. Pozzo offers a hundred francs and then two hundred as an inducement for someone to help him. Vladimir goes to raise him, but falls in the attempt and cries out for help himself. After further conversation, Estragon tries to lift Vladimir and falls too. Vladimir strikes Pozzo, who crawls away. Vladimir then seeks him out and calls, "Come back; I won't hurt you."

Estragon and Vladimir think about getting up and manage to rise. Estragon remarks that standing up is as easy as child's play; Vladimir says it is merely a question of willpower. Pozzo calls for help. Together they lift him, then release him, and he falls again. They raise him once more and keep hold of him, occasionally slackening their grip to test whether he can stand, only to catch him when he starts to fall. Pozzo too seems to have forgotten yesterday's events. He says he went to bed one day and awoke blind. He even wonders whether he is still asleep. He asks after Lucky and does not seem to remember how they fell. Pozzo suggests that Lucky will get up if the rope around his neck is pulled hard or he is kicked in the face. Vladimir tells Estragon that he has a fine opportunity for revenge. Estragon asks—his memory returning!—what if Lucky defends himself? Pozzo replies that Lucky never defends himself. Estragon, or rather Vladimir, starts kicking Lucky, only to hurt himself. Meanwhile Pozzo appears to have got to his feet unaided.

Pozzo, who is taking Lucky to a market to sell him, remembers nothing of yesterday and will remember nothing of today tomorrow. He orders Lucky to get up, and Lucky rises and takes up his burdens. Pozzo asks for his whip. Lucky puts everything down, places the whip in Pozzo's hand, and lifts the burdens again. Pozzo asks for the rope; Lucky sets down everything, hands Pozzo the rope and shoulders everything once more!

Lucky and Pozzo leave. The boy returns and addresses Vladimir as Albert. Vladimir asks whether the boy does not recognise him and whether he did not come yesterday. The boy says this is his first visit. The message is unchanged: Godot will not come today but will certainly come tomorrow. Vladimir asks what Godot does; the boy replies that Godot does nothing. Vladimir asks about the boy's brother. The reply is that his brother is unhappy. Asked whether his brother came yesterday, the boy says he does not know. He adds that Godot has a beard, and that it is fair rather than black. As in the first act, he asks what he should tell Godot. Vladimir says,

"Tell him you met us." Vladimir rushes at the boy, but the boy runs away. The sun sets, and the moon appears.

Estragon says it might be better for them both if they parted. If Godot does not come tomorrow, Vladimir says, they will hang themselves with a rope; if he does come, they will be saved. Vladimir looks inside Lucky's hat, shakes it and puts it on. They resolve to leave, but neither moves. The curtain falls.

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Harold Pinter's Three-Act Play The Birthday Party

The characters are Petey, Meg, Stanley, Lulu, Goldberg and McCann.

Act One: Meg gives Petey breakfast and asks whether Stanley is up. Stanley comes in, and Meg gives him breakfast too. Petey goes to work. Meg and Stanley talk intimately, joking with each other. Petey has told Meg that two men will arrive and stay for a few days in their house, which operates as a boarding house. Stanley questions her on hearing this and becomes worried. Stanley claims to have received an offer to play the piano in a nightclub in Paris, followed by Athens, Constantinople, Zagreb and Vladivostok—a job that would take him round the whole world. When asked, he says he has performed the piano throughout the world, in every country. He has given a concert once, he says; then he says he lost the address of the venue for his first concert and could not get there. When he arrived for the second, he found the place locked. Meg does not want Stanley to go anywhere.

Stanley feels that the two visitors are looking for someone. Lulu is heard. Meg leaves with a shopping bag; someone calls her Mrs Boles while speaking to her. Lulu enters and talks with Stanley. After Lulu leaves, Goldberg and McCann arrive. McCann calls Goldberg Nat. Stanley has already slipped away unnoticed. Meg enters, and Goldberg addresses her as Mrs Boles and introduces himself as Goldberg and his companion as McCann. In the ensuing conversation Goldberg asks the name and occupation of the lodger. Meg says his name is Stanley Webber and that he once gave a concert, but owing to a caretaker's mistake he was locked inside the venue overnight and remained there until morning. He then took his "tip," boarded a train and arrived here. Meg suddenly says it is Stanley's birthday. A birthday party is fixed for nine o'clock, and Lulu too will be invited in the afternoon. The three leave, and Stanley peers through the window. Meg returns. Stanley is apprehensive about the two men. When he asks their names, Meg forgets, then recalls "Gold ...," at which Stanley supplies "Goldberg." Meg asks if Stanley knows him, but Stanley says nothing. He then declares that today is not his birthday. Meg has brought him a child's drum as a present and asks for a kiss in return.

Act Two: Stanley and McCann are talking. Stanley wants to go out. He tells McCann that this is not a boarding house and never has been one. Petey and Goldberg come in. Goldberg addresses Petey as Mr Boles. After Petey leaves, Stanley says the people of the house have lost their sense of smell and cannot recognise the danger posed by Goldberg and McCann. He, Stanley, has a responsibility towards them.

McCann snatches Stanley's spectacles. McCann and Goldberg ask why he murdered his wife. They accuse him of having changed his name, of immorality and of corrupting women.

A quarrel breaks out. When it ends, Meg, apparently unaware of what has happened, enters in party clothes. Ordinary conversation follows.

Lulu arrives, and Goldberg seats her on his lap. When she says she thought his name was "Nat," Goldberg replies that his wife calls him "Simey."

The party game begins, with players blindfolded. Lulu ties a scarf around Mrs Boles's eyes; whoever she touches must next be blindfolded. She touches McCann, then Stanley is touched. His spectacles are taken away and he is blindfolded. McCann breaks Stanley's spectacles and places the drum in his path. Stanley falls and attempts to strangle Meg, but McCann and Goldberg intervene to save her.

Darkness spreads.

At the sight of Stanley approaching, Lulu faints. Stanley lays her on a table. McCann finds a torch and shines it on the table and on Stanley.

Act Three: Petey and Meg converse. Meg asks Petey about Stanley. Lulu enters and asks Goldberg what her father or Eddie, her first lover, would think if they heard of this. She says Goldberg has satisfied his wicked lust, teaching Lulu things a young woman would otherwise learn only after marrying three times. Goldberg says he did so because Lulu allowed him to.

Lulu leaves.

While Meg is absent, Goldberg and McCann take Stanley away. Petey tells them to leave him alone. Goldberg and McCann invite Petey to come along too, saying there is room in the car. Petey does not move. Left alone, he is joined by Meg. She asks whether they have gone. Petey says yes. She asks about Stanley—"Is he asleep?" Petey says he is.

"Let him sleep."

Meg asks whether it was not a good party. Petey says he arrived later.

The curtain falls.

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Badal Sircar's Evam Indrajit

The characters of Evam Indrajit include the Writer, his Aunt, Manasi, Amal, Vimal, Kamal, Indrajit and, later, Indrajit's wife, another Manasi.

Act One: The Writer is in search of a play. His aunt is annoyed that he keeps writing and neglects food and drink. Manasi asks whether she may read what he has written. He says he has written nothing, and she urges him to try. The Writer calls four late arrivals from the audience on to the stage. Three are Amal, Vimal and Kamal. The fourth calls himself Nirmal Kumar. The Writer says that cannot be true and tells him to reveal his real name. He says it is Indrajit Ray. Thus: Amal, Vimal, Kamal and Indrajit. Manasi—her real name is different, but the Writer calls her Manasi—is Indrajit's maternal cousin. He loves her and wants to break with convention.

Act Two: Later Indrajit wonders whether the success of their love would give him an answer. Surely not. He will go to London too. He wants death but cannot bring himself to it. The Manasi named by the Writer remains unmarried and teaches in Hazaribagh.

Unlike Amal, Vimal and Kamal, however, Indrajit does not follow a fixed track. He wants to do something different. His aunt, whom he calls Mother, tells him to eat, while Manasi tells him to write. But once, when Manasi herself tells the Writer to eat, he is hurt: "You too? No!"

Manasi realises her mistake and asks about his writing. The Writer is worried: Indrajit refuses to accept reality and has no commitment. Manasi disagrees.

At least he dreams.

Indrajit returns from London to Calcutta and marries another woman, also called Manasi (Indrajit calls her Manasi; the earlier Manasi, whom the Writer named thus, is Indrajit's maternal cousin, whom he loves but cannot marry because of their familial relationship and what people would say. Indrajit continues to tell the Writer that her name is not Manasi).

Indrajit begins to realise, and tells Manasi, that individual difference is only an illusion. A dream is a dream; it cannot become reality. Manasi, Manasi, Manasi: they are all Manasi, just as Amal, Vimal and Kamal are alike. When the Writer asks, Indrajit responds, "Amal, Vimal, Kamal—and Indrajit too!"

The Writer's journey has neither destination nor purpose; it is a pointless journey undertaken for no reason. The Writer tells Indrajit that we must

live and go on walking; though there is no holy shrine, we must undertake the pilgrimage nevertheless.

Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s No Entry: Ma Pravish

First Kallola: This play, in the tradition of Jyotirishwar, is divided into kallolas. (Jyotirishwar's Varna Ratnakara, which is not a play, is arranged in kallolas, whereas his play Dhurtasamagama is divided into acts.) The first of its four kallolas begins at the gate of heaven—or hell. A large crowd of dead people waits in a queue to enter. Among them are a respectable gentleman killed in a road accident, soldiers who died in battle, and a thief, a rogue and a pickpocket killed in the course of stealing. The remarkably modern absurdity visible in Jyotirishwar's Dhurtasamagama also appears in No Entry: Ma Pravish. In the first kallola, the gentleman, on seeing the thief and the rogue break the queue, seizes them by their collars and drags them back to their original places. The rogue, who later turns out to be a local gangster but is at present posing as a respectable man, demands that the gentleman release his shirt. But when the pickpocket speaks in support of the gentleman against the thief, the rogue produces a knife, reveals his true nature and lunges at the pickpocket. Then the thief says the pickpocket is one of their own fraternity, though he could progress no farther than petty pickpocketing: he never became a seasoned thief like himself, much less a gangster like the rogue. At this the rogue turns against the thief: "Whom did you call a scoundrel?" The pickpocket seizes his chance and changes sides, telling the rogue that the thief meant not him but the pickpocket. He adds that the thief is such an accomplished thief that the householder's sons and dogs beat him during a theft and sent him here, yet he makes fun of me as if he were some great thief. Observing the thief's conduct, the respectable gentleman finds it hard to believe that he really is a thief. The pickpocket needles the thief still further. The thief then laments that had he not taken the pickpocket stealing that night, he would never have had to witness him being beaten. The gentleman, who earlier dragged the thief and rogue back by their collars, listens in silence and wonders sadly what heaven will be like if he must live among such people there. He recites a fragment of song on the subject. Just as there are songs in Dhurtasamagama, so there are songs in No Entry: Ma Pravish; they begin at this point and turn it into a musical drama. Meanwhile the pickpocket steals everyone's pocketbooks and empties their wallets. Another musical rhyme begins, but a dead ragpicker breaks the spell by announcing that beyond the locked gate of Yama's abode wallets and money have no use. Two other deceased respectable gentlemen agree: another country's coins do not circulate in a foreign land. A dead gallant named Ramanimohan remarks on this inability to use foreign currency: it is just like one's beloved becoming another man's wife. This provokes a quarrel, and

Ramanimohan changes the subject by suggesting that Rambha and Menaka will be inside the gates. A woman beggar, who has handed the child in her lap to someone else and joined the discussion, jealously abuses Rambha and Menaka. The pickpocket, however, suggests that what lies inside might be suffering rather than pleasure. At this the insurance agent is delighted to discover a new scope for his business. The pickpocket now begins taking bids in rupees for Indra's thunderbolt. This time the gentleman breaks the spell, and the two respectable men support him: it is the strangest auction they have ever heard of, run by a pickpocket and attended by a thief and a beggar. Musical rhymes begin again. Suddenly Nandi and Bhringi enter, dancing to classical music. When asked what lies beyond the gate, everyone answers in accordance with their beliefs—heaven or hell, sky or netherworld. Nandi and Bhringi say that all have spoken some truth but none the whole truth. They begin enumerating the circumstances of death: some were killed while stealing (the thief tries to flee when he hears this but two or three people catch him and bring him forward); others died in accidents, and so on. They cannot understand how the insurance agent has arrived without dying. He explains that he has come to explore a new market! Thus there is one person there who is not dead. Bhringi explains to Nandi the competition caused by the proliferation of insurance companies. Meanwhile a lovers' quarrel breaks out because the young man wants to return. Ramanimohan is pleased at the prospect of his departure: the young woman would then be left alone and he would have his chance. Bhringi explains that it is impossible to go back; perhaps they could arrange an accident for both pairs of parents and bring them here. But neither lover is willing to sacrifice their parents for personal happiness. Nandi and Bhringi then solemnise their marriage with music and celebration, and the gentleman gives away the bride.

Second Kallola: The second kallola begins with the sense that a political leader is about to arrive after his death. His two followers have already arrived dead, and everyone waits for their leader. The followers compensate for his delayed arrival—even after death!—by delivering short speeches interspersed with songs. The thief cannot understand one of the songs, but the beggar woman and the ragpicker do, and an argument begins. The thief objects to being called a thief. When he calls the woman a beggar, she stops him: she is Anasuya of Sarisab-Pahi, a Mithila painter. But after moving to Ashok Basti in Delhi, she discovered that no one in that city would buy her artworks and ended up begging at the crossroads. The thief insists that only he is disgraced, though everyone steals; there is nothing new, only the thefts of the old guard. Then Netaji arrives and attributes the presence of thieves, rogues and pickpockets to social conditions. A leftist enters and is indignant to find the leader surrounded

by such people. The thief returns with his argument, and, taking his cue from the leader's "Purana of Thieves," the gentleman launches into song.

Third Kallola: The discussion now turns to the alliance between Netaji and the leftist and to the leftist's support of a government from outside. Netaji again becomes musical, but everyone's attention is diverted by the arrival of a dead actor, Vivek Kumar, performing a stunt scene. Netaji satirises the compulsion to deliver fresh, breaking news. The leftist makes two contradictory-sounding observations at different points: first, that nobody can become a leader without being an actor; second, that a thief cannot become a leader. The thief responds that political leaders are second to none when it comes to stealing. A woman of high birth then arrives. After some questioning, a VIP queue forms alongside the ordinary queue. The actor, political leader and leftist all join the VIP line! Asked why they have made a queue, the thief and pickpocket explain that they are well practised in forming—and breaking—queues.

Fourth Kallola: Yamaraj examines everyone's accounts, and Chitragupta reveals that there was once an age when the gate ahead could both open and close. Nandi and Bhringi have already explained that the gate is not a dream; the problem is merely one of understanding. Asked what lies beyond, everyone supplies an answer from their own perspective. Chitragupta says that everything mentioned in these descriptions exists on the other side. Nandi and Bhringi announce that entry through this gate is prohibited: a NO ENTRY sign is displayed there. Good heavens! What now? Netaji is sent before Yamaraj, but his eloquence deserts him. The celebrated leader Badri Vishal Mishra is taken to task for the age on his certificate, which is lower than his real age. His horoscope says he is fifty-five and that, having Shasha Yoga, he will live beyond seventy; he is therefore sent back, together with the four dead soldiers. Two soldiers accompany Netaji, and his two followers also want to go, but their crimes are too serious. At Chitragupta's command, Nandi and Bhringi lead the followers away to be roasted in a cauldron; the two remaining soldiers seize them and take them away, while Nandi and Bhringi return to the stage. Similarly, after argument, the young couple, the two respectable men and the gentleman receive deliverance and are escorted out to drums and pipes. When Nandi calls the actor "Vivek Kumar alias ...," the actor interrupts: with such labour he had managed to leave caste behind him, so let the "alias" be omitted. The leftist disputes the actor's account of having helped a leftist gathering. He too is to be sent away. But what is to become of the leftist? His worldview has neither heaven and hell nor Yamaraj and Chitragupta. He is offered the opportunity to decide his own future. He says his education taught him something quite different, yet how can he disbelieve what is now happening before his eyes? Yamaraj replies that perhaps what he sees is a nightmare: wherever he goes, the sign says NO

ENTRY. Yamaraj asks which is more unequal, human beings or nature. The leftist replies that both are, though nature may sometimes possess natural justice; where is there any room for it in human nature? Left-wing politics nevertheless tries to secure equality and reform. He is therefore sent back with the thief, rogue and pickpocket, given an opportunity to change them. The thief hesitates and asks: we are leaving, but what lies beyond here? Nandi, Chitragupta and Yamaraj answer in unison: "No entry." Bhringi returns, having seen off the actor. Yamaraj says, "Ma Pravish—Do not enter." Bhringi reports discussion below about changing the rules and permitting more people to return to earth. Yama's attendants stand pointlessly beside the cauldron; they have found nobody to roast, apart from the two followers. Everyone says that no one is left to arrive. Chitragupta removes his long beard and Yamaraj his crown, revealing their ordinary human forms! The beggar woman, still present, laughs when she sees Chitragupta's long false beard. Bhringi discloses that the beggar woman, too, is a performer like them. What acting! The account of her performance ends in love and teasing, but the beggar woman points out that the real performance is occurring over there. Ramanimohan is courting a high-born woman named Nibha, who remains silent. The beggar woman tells Yamaraj that Nibha will speak only when she receives the key to the lock on the gate; she thinks Yamaraj can help her become an apsara. Such is a woman's heart—"No entry" even here! Yamaraj coughs, and Chitragupta realises that Yamaraj has been struck by the five arrows of Kama. At Chitragupta's instruction everyone moves to one side, leaving only Yamaraj and Nibha onstage. Yamaraj begins, "Listen, Nibha ...," but stops. Encouraged by the others, he gives her a large key. Once she has it, however, Nibha moves towards Ramanimohan as though she knows nobody else! She hands him the key, but he cannot open the lock. She then steps forward to try herself, only for Chitragupta to say that this is the door of the mind and cannot be opened in that way. The woman complains that giving her the key was a trick. Everyone laughs: where have you left your mind? Once again Ramanimohan and Nibha bring their minds together and try unsuccessfully to open the lock. Nandi, Bhringi and the beggar woman sing a song whose burden is that the heart's lock is fastened and the sign there says NO ENTRY. Yet in the spring season love is boundless and the heart cries "Maina, Maina." So let a sit-in be staged right here, at the NO ENTRY gate.

Critical Discussion: A comparative study of Indian and Western dramatic theory reveals how much human thought can have in common despite geographical distance. Indian dramaturgy is based principally on Bharata's Natyashastra and Dhananjaya's Dasharupaka. Aristotle's Poetics is the authoritative work of Western dramatic theory.

Bharata describes drama as following action and imitating emotion; Dhananjaya defines drama as the imitation of states or situations. In Indian literary theory, imitation is the actor's work, not the poet's. In the Western tradition, imitation is the poet's activity, and the actor receives no comparable discussion there.

Aristotle gives special emphasis to plot in drama. Along with plot, tragedy contains characterisation, diction, thought, spectacle and song. Bharata calls the plot concerning the hero the principal plot, or adhikarika, while a story that assists the principal plot is prasangika, incidental. But incidental plots are not essential to every play. No Entry: Ma Pravish has neither a clearly principal plot nor an incidental one, since no single character is recognised by all as the hero. The gentleman who seizes the rogue by the collar becomes secondary a little later. The rogue, before whom the thief initially trembles, subsequently comes forward philosophising that nothing new ever happens. Yamaraj, before whom everyone quakes, finds his own force diminished in the presence of Nibha. The beggar woman laughs at him as he discards his divine appearance, and in the end Ramanimohan and Nibha even abuse both him and Chitragupta. The leftist and the actor meet similar reversals. No character is intrinsically weak; each reacts and rebounds according to time and circumstance.

In the classification of plots by source, there are three kinds: prakhyata, utpadya and mishra—renowned, invented and mixed. A renowned story comes from history or the Puranas; an invented story is fictional; a mixed one combines the two. In No Entry: Ma Pravish, any possibility of classifying the plot as mixed disappears when Chitragupta and Yamaraj shed their disguises and the beggar woman laughs, prompting Bhringi to say she is an actor just like them. Merely using the names Yamaraj and Chitragupta does not link the narrative to history or Purana; the plot is entirely invented. Aristotle distinguishes simple and complex plots. Judged by the ease with which unexpected incidents flow into No Entry: Ma Pravish, this is a play with a simple plot. Aristotle also relates narratives to fable, fiction and history; by that scheme, No Entry: Ma Pravish belongs to the imaginative or fictional category. Aristotle's tragic characters are distinguished and of high birth, combining good and bad qualities. Every character in No Entry: Ma Pravish has a combination of good and evil. Nibha is of high birth, yet she becomes intimate with Ramanimohan, who died after being beaten following a rape. The beggar woman is Anasuya, a painter from Mithila. Yet the two respectable gentlemen, the other gentleman and the four soldiers appear without this kind of moral stain. Bharata calls the lover of dance and music dhiralalita, one of calm temperament dhiraprasanta, a person of heroic or warrior disposition dhirodatta, and one consumed by jealousy dhiroddhata. The gentleman

and two respectable men love music, while Ramanimohan is jealous of the young lovers. The soldiers are peaceful and also possess the virtues of warriors, making them both dhirodatta and dhiraprasanta. But such classifications cannot be applied completely to No Entry: Ma Pravish.

Indian theory describes five stages of dramatic action: commencement (arambha), effort (prayatna), hope of attainment (praptyasha), certainty of attainment (niyatapti) and attainment of the fruit (phalagama). At the stage of praptyasha, doubts about the result arise; at niyatapti, hope returns. Western theory has exposition, rising action, climax, falling action and denouement. The first three produce complications, while the last two bring resolution.

The five elements in the development of action are seed (bija), drop (bindu), subsidiary episode (pataka), subordinate incident (prakari) and the completed action (karya). In No Entry: Ma Pravish, the seed is a conflict involving people after death, although the insurance agent arrives there without dying. Yamaraj and Chitragupta turn out to be performers in disguise. At various points, one character rises and another falls in importance. Pataka and prakari belong to subsidiary narrative strands and are absent from No Entry: Ma Pravish. Karya is the developed form of the seed, but this play ends with a sit-in demonstration! Aristotle calls these the beginning, middle and end. Consider now the dramatic junctures, or sandhis: the mukha-sandhi joins seed and commencement; the pratimukha joins bindu and effort; the garbha joins pataka and hope of attainment; the vimarsha joins prakari and certainty of attainment; and the nirvahana joins the completed action and the arrival of the result. In No Entry: Ma Pravish, only the mukha, pratimukha and nirvahana junctures appear; the other two are absent.

Western theory seeks the unities of place, time and action. In No Entry: Ma Pravish the place remains the same, time is continuous, and the action concerns the wish to enter the gate. A two-hour play presents events occupying two hours, and its central action is singular. Abhinavagupta likewise says that a single act should not cover more than a day and two acts should not encompass more than a year. The divisions into kallolas in No Entry: Ma Pravish arise from actions occurring within specified periods and from the delays before new actions begin. Dryden, however, opposed these three unities and defended the freedom of Shakespeare's plays. No such problem arises in No Entry: Ma Pravish. In its conversations—which may also be called flashbacks—the manner of each character's death is clearly revealed.

Indian theory supported drama as something to be seen, whereas Aristotle and Plato opposed the emphasis on spectacle. In the sixteenth century, however, Lodovico Castelvetro supported stage presentation. D'Aubignac

also supported its visual dimension, while Dryden defended the readability of drama. Dacier supported both reading and performance. Abhinavagupta maintained that the complete relish of rasa comes from enacted performance, though rasa can also be enjoyed through reading. At the very beginning of the first kallola of No Entry: Ma Pravish, it becomes clear that primacy is given to theatrical visibility. Western staging tends towards representation of the real, while Indian theatrical practice is symbolic. For example, in Abhijnanashakuntalam, Kalidasa writes: "iti sharasandhanam natayati"—he acts as though drawing an arrow. No Entry: Ma Pravish adopts an Indian convention: the invisible wall at the entrance to heaven is made comprehensible through dialogue and the acting of the dead. Performance had primacy in Ankiya Nata too. Kirtaniya drama was in one sense musical, yet acting was also central to it. Ankiya plays began with the beating of the mridanga. No Entry: Ma Pravish attaches itself to the Maithili tradition while introducing a new way of seeing history, Purana and the cycles of contemporary life, offering fresh insights for reflection.

Continuing the tradition of Jyotirishwar's Dhurtasamagama, Vidyapati's Gorakshavijaya, the Kirtaniya plays and Ankiya Nata, Munshi Raghunandan Das's Mithila Nataka, Jivan Jha's Sundar Sanyog, Ishanath Jha's Chinik Laddu, Govind Jha's Basat, Manipadma's Tesar Kaniya, Nachiketa's Nayakak Nam Jivan and Ek Chhal Raja, Shrishji's Purushartha, Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary's Bhafait Chahak Jingi, Mahendra Malangia's Kathak Lok, Ram Bharos Kapari "Bhramar"'s Mahishasur Murdabad, and Gangesh Gunjan's Budhibadhiya, Nachiketa's No Entry: Ma Pravish repeatedly rejects rationality and the claimed objectivity of modernity. Yamaraj even tells the leftist that what he sees may not be true; it may be a dream. The play comments upon the pretensions of complete scientific knowledge. Truth and falsehood are described differently from each perspective. The thief has his own arguments, while the leftist insists that a thief cannot become a political leader, even though the political leader's own stealing threatens to destroy the thief's livelihood. The play's self-centred humour and its notions of good and evil continually appear and dissolve. Even Yamaraj and Chitragupta are living behind masks. Alongside these postmodern traits, No Entry: Ma Pravish brings out several different characters within one person, as with the high-born lady. No event yields a definitive meaning; one never knows when truth will turn into falsehood. The play is filled with superficial postmodern reflection and such characters. It is not optimistic, but neither is it pessimistic. What it offers is apparent madness, a view that anything can be considered in many ways rather than only one. There is less faith in results produced by causes, control and planning than in outcomes produced by chance. Democratic and feminist perspectives,

the ideology of the red flag and other currents are presented through symbolic humour and satire.

Thus No Entry: Ma Pravish presents a postmodern outlook in which readers encounter many different problems raised in the course of the narrative. The conflict shown at its conclusion does not surprise readers of the postmodern age, for they meet such contradictions every day.

Postmodern, Emotion-Centred Absurd Drama: Samuel Beckett himself translated En attendant Godot from French into English as Waiting for Godot, adding the subtitle "A Tragicomedy in Two Acts," which did not appear in the French version. Tragicomedy combines tragedy and comedy. The plot makes clear that the apparent central figure, Godot, never appears in the play; moreover, emotionally he is not its essential element. The essential element is "waiting." Language, stage, speech, silence and modes of movement are integral to the play. Its central figures are wanderers whose lives pass through space and time. They perform like mime artists, conveying meaning physically without words. The play creates a new definition of plot and dramatic balance, and ushers modern theatre into a new era. Britain's music-hall theatre brought music and humour together; Beckett uses cross-talk to show life's despair, while Harold Pinter depicts political and social terror through humour. No Entry: Ma Pravish likewise begins at a gate to heaven—or hell—where all the dead are standing in a queue, yet a living person is among them! The rogue behaves respectfully before the gentleman! The lovers even marry there! Netaji is condemned to arrive late even after death! The leftist offers support from outside there too! Nor is anyone spared the VIP queue! But Chitragupta reveals that in an earlier age the gate before which everyone waits both opened and closed. If it will no longer open, what is the point of waiting? Nandi and Bhringi say that the gate was no dream; there had merely been a failure of understanding. When asked his surname, the actor Vivek Kumar says he freed himself from caste only with the greatest difficulty, so the "alias" should be dropped. The leftist's worldview contains no heaven or hell and no Yamaraj or Chitragupta, yet faced with the scene before him how can he disbelieve it? It is Yamaraj himself who tells him that the scene may be a nightmare. Yama's attendants stand pointlessly beside their cauldron with nobody to roast. When the beggar woman laughs at Chitragupta's false beard, Bhringi reveals that she too is an actor. And how can the door of the mind be opened if one has left one's mind behind?

The French play Waiting for Godot, Harold Pinter's English play The Birthday Party, Badal Sircar's Bangla play Evam Indrajit, and Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa"'s Maithili play No Entry: Ma Pravish all depart from the clearly delimited beginnings and endings of older drama. They begin at some apparently arbitrary point and end somewhere else. In Evam

Indrajit, the Writer searches for a character and suddenly addresses the auditorium, calling four latecomers onstage and turning them into characters. The fourth is especially dear to him: he is not Nirmal but Indrajit, the historically resonant name of one who conquered Indra. Unlike Amal, Vimal and Kamal, he will not follow an established track. Yet by the end Indrajit too becomes simply one more among Amal, Vimal, Kamal—and Indrajit.

Harold Pinter's The Birthday Party initially received such hostile reviews that his writing career appeared to be nearing its end. Yet subsequent readings made it a classic. Pinter sustains an atmosphere of mystery and terror throughout, strengthening his comic material. Who is Stanley? Who was he, or who does he want to become? Does he corrupt women, or has he murdered his wife? Yet Meg likes him. Who obstructed his first and second concerts? Is he lying, or does he simply behave outside existing social and political definitions? He attempts to strangle Meg, yet why does she continue to like him? Why, and how, do social and political powers carry him away, when their agents Goldberg—with his mysterious conduct towards Lulu—and McCann can scarcely represent any moral ideal themselves?

The stage of Waiting for Godot is a bare tree without leaves and a mound beside a deserted road; the stage of No Entry: Ma Pravish is the space outside a locked gate; in Evam Indrajit, the auditorium itself becomes the stage. The room of a house forms the stage of The Birthday Party, but Pinter sometimes breaks Stanley into fragments and sometimes reassembles him, in a process that recalls Derridean deconstruction. Spectators alternately envy, pity and hate Stanley; yet when he seems powerless before Goldberg and McCann, they recognise themselves in him, just as they identify with Indrajit in Evam Indrajit. In Waiting for Godot, just as the audience identifies with a slave and feels sympathy, it is astonished when an act of compassion earns a blow. In No Entry: Ma Pravish, the beggar woman jealously abuses Rambha and Menaka! The pickpocket offers a cash bid for Indra's thunderbolt. Nandi and Bhringi tell everyone: you have all spoken truth, but no one has spoken the whole truth. In Evam Indrajit, Indrajit's condition resembles that of Sisyphus, the cursed figure of Greek myth, condemned to push a marble boulder upwards, only for the stone to roll down again when he reaches the top. Are human labour and life founded upon meaninglessness? Is humanity condemned to failure, like Indrajit? Or can the leftist in No Entry: Ma Pravish change his view on seeing what contradicts his disbelief in heaven, hell, Yamaraj and Chitragupta? Yet Yamaraj himself says that what one sees may be a nightmare. Waiting for Godot is not a wait for God: Beckett himself says the characters wait for “Godot,” not “God,” though he uses

Christianity as mythology. In existentialist thought, human beings and the universe are without inherent meaning—absurd.

The ghazal poet Om Prakash Jha; Rajdev Mandal's Ambara; Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jharudar," the first people's poet of Maithili in the tradition of Bhikhari Thakur; the ghazal poet Munna Ji and the short-story writer Munna Ji; Ramvilas Sahu; Umesh Mandal's Nishtuki; Umesh Paswan's Varnit Ras; Sujit's Jiddi; Vineet Thakur's Banki Achhi Hamar Dudhak Karj; Santosh Kumar Mishra's "Ena Kiye ...?" and "Posput"; and Mahendra Malangia's Chhutaha Ghail.

105. Sharadindu Chaudhary's Memoir Literature

Abstract

Sharadindu Chaudhary's memoir literature [Baat-Baat Par Baat (I–IV)] comprises four collections of autobiographical essays: Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume I; Marmantak—Shabdanubhuti (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume II); Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume III); and Sakshat (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume IV). The first appeared in 2019, the second in 2020, and the third and fourth in 2021. His 2002 volume Jan Ham Janitahun is likewise a collection of memoir-essays tinged with humour and satire. It names award-hungry writers of the literary mainstream, whose conduct is such that the reminiscences almost automatically become humorous and satirical. Yet this is not a book of pure memoir: there is some added spice, although only a little.

Keywords: Sharadindu · Chaudhary · memoir · discussion · by · also · book

Abstract

Sharadindu Chaudhary's memoir literature [Baat-Baat Par Baat (I–IV)] comprises four collections of autobiographical essays: Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume I; Marmantak—Shabdanubhuti (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume II); Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume III); and Sakshat (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume IV). The first appeared in 2019, the second in 2020, and the third and fourth in 2021. His 2002 volume Jan Ham Janitahun is likewise a collection of memoir-essays tinged with humour and satire. It names award-hungry writers of the literary mainstream, whose conduct is such that the reminiscences almost automatically become humorous and satirical. Yet this is not a book of pure memoir: there is some added spice, although only a little. It is a matter of satisfaction that Sharadindu has not encountered a single such covetous individual in the parallel literary movement.

Sharadindu Chaudhary's Memoir Literature [Baat-Baat Par Baat (I–IV)]

Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume I; Marmantak—Shabdanubhuti (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume II); Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume III); and Sakshat (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume IV): these four books collect Sharadindu Chaudhary's memoir-essays. The first appeared in 2019, the second in 2020, and the third and fourth in 2021.

His Jan Ham Janitahun, published in 2002, also collects memoir-essays with humour and satire. It names award-hungry writers of the literary mainstream; their activities are such that the recollections become, almost

of their own accord, a work of humour and satire. Still, the volume is not a collection of unadulterated memoirs: it contains some seasoning, though not very much. Happily, Sharadindu has encountered no such acquisitive person in the parallel literary movement.

In addition, Bar Ajagut Dekhal (2005), Gobarganesh (2011) and Kariya Kakkak Koramin (2016) may be regarded as a Kariya Kakka series of satires, since a figure named Kariya Kakka, rather like Khattar Kakka, appears in all three. He is absent, however, from some individual pieces, including "Tavat Kaal," "Golaisi—Arthat" and "CD Samiksha" in Gobarganesh. All three collections are broadly grounded in recollection, but here the seasoning is far stronger. In the author's note to Kariya Kakkak Koramin, Chaudhary writes that Kariya Kakka did whatever occurred to him, while taking care that "... no accusation of obscenity should arise." Yet in the "CD Samiksha" published five years earlier in Gobarganesh, he writes of Vidyanath Jha "Vidit," chair of the Maithili Advisory Board elected by organisations designated "literary associations" by the Sahitya Akademi: "... He himself is a connoisseur of pleasure. With Pravasi-ji he will perform his evening devotions; with Thakurain he will sing a duet..." In "Tavat Kaal" in the same book, we read: "The Sahitya Akademi conducted an experiment of precisely this kind: even a person who owned a hotel could become a member of the advisory board." The description in "Tavat Kaal" is not obscene, but the description in "CD Samiksha" plainly is. It is evident that all the chairs of the Maithili Advisory Board chosen by the Sahitya Akademi's so-called literary associations worked to bring Maithili to ruin; but why should a woman among them be treated as a veritable King Harishchandra? Sexist comments about her demonstrate a lack of sensitivity on the author's or editor's part towards women and people of genders other than male, in literature as well as in public life. This insensitivity is also apparent in "Sarkarak Linga Pariksha" in Kariya Kakkak Koramin, where the phrase "a government endowed with feminine qualities" is applied to Vinod Kumar Jha [see "Irshya Dvesh Nahi—Samanvay Chahi" in Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume III), where "government" refers to Vinod Kumar Jha, now dubbed "Emperor of Poets"].

1

Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume I

In "Shreya and Preya" in Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume I, Chaudhary discusses Shyamanand Chaudhary's role in securing the reintroduction of Maithili into the Bihar Public Service Commission examinations and in preparing its syllabus. Sharadindu obtained a copy of the syllabus, which had gone missing from the Commission office, from the late Chaudhary-

ji, proprietor of "Jha Ji Bookseller Ki Dukan" near the Commission gate, and gave it to Shyamanand Chaudhary, then Special Officer of the Bihar Public Service Commission. On 20 December 2018, Shyamanand said that not a single Maithili institution had submitted a written proposal to the government on the matter. Nevertheless, the Chetana Samiti formally claimed the credit and celebrated it! "Ham Abhari Chhi" discusses the subsequent removal of Sharadindu Chaudhary's name from the 2010 Mithila Ratna awards list, even after Baidyanath Chaudhary "Baiju" had issued a press release or announcement. The awarding organisation was the Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, recognised by the Sahitya Akademi as a so-called literary association. Its selection panel included Dr Bhimnath Jha, Dr Phoolchandra Mishra "Raman" and Kamalakant Jha. Pandit Chandranath Mishra "Amar," president of the Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, reportedly threatened to swallow poison if Sharadindu were honoured. "Ham Nahi Kahi Sakait Chhi..." discusses the politics of Vinod Kumar Jha and the Maithili Lekhak Sangh, which failed to secure Sahitya Akademi recognition as one of its so-called literary associations. It also recounts how, in matters of registration, everyone except Vinod-ji remained content to play the grand gentleman. Several allegations were made against Mantreshwar Jha in meetings; Premlata Mishra "Prem," Indira Jha and Panna Jha are depicted as standing about like statues in their eagerness to be regarded as intellectuals. The Maithili Lekhak Sangh now has a permanent president and a permanent secretary, but the association itself has vanished. Such, too, is the condition of the Akademi's supposed literary associations. Vidyanath Jha "Vidit," who had served as the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili officer for five years, apparently desired Sharadindu's "active cooperation" (!). "Hamar Durgun A Krodhak Dushprabhav" refers to a young writer-journalist from Laheriasarai who alleged in a newspaper, under a pseudonym, that Sharadindu was making money by blackmailing the Sahitya Akademi, Maithili Academy and Chetana Samiti. Of the Chetana Samiti, Sharadindu writes: "... Had I not been a journalist, certain people might even have beaten me up. Everyone knows how disgracefully a former secretary of the Samiti was harassed after he opposed it. Nevertheless, I did not meet with that fate."

"Samay-Salak Janma A Sahityik-Rajnitik Kuchakra" discusses a letter from Vinod Bihari Lal, who wrote, "Well, your wish to have your name recorded in history as an editor will at least be fulfilled." In 2001, Rajmohan Jha organised a campaign opposing the Sahitya Akademi Award for the late Babuaji Jha Agyat's epic Pratigya Pandav, spreading the false assertion that the book had never been published. Sharadindu refused to sign that petition, and Rajmohan wrote all manner of nonsense about him in Antika. It should be added that Sharadindu procured a copy of the printed book and even displayed it at his shop in Patna. The essay also

recalls Rajmohan's eventual admission of his mistake and Sharadindu's restoration of goodwill towards him. "Naukari Nahi Karbak Nirnay" discusses Agnipushp: "Only journalists like Agnipushp could do such things—roaring at Aryavarta with threats to cut down an elephant, then working at Jagran with their tails tucked between their legs until retirement." It also mentions Shiv Kumar Thakur, a press manager and compositor: "Be that as it may, he rose from compositor to proprietor; that is what pleases me." In my view Sharadindu is rather too harsh on Shiv Kumar Thakur. Many people visited the Chetana Samiti's Vidyapati Bhavan only because of his bookshop. Even the Samiti could not tolerate it: it was busy booking its own marriage hall, so why would it sell books? But it certainly managed to have Shiv Kumar Thakur's shop closed. Be that as it may. "Jivan Yuddhak Bhumika" discusses the assistance, cooperation and advice supplied by friends Dilip, Ajit Azad, Abhay Jha, Pandit Tarakant Jha, Mantreshwar Jha and Basuki Babu. "Sammank Bhukh" portrays the prize-hungry writers of the mainstream: "People probably know the story of respected Govind Babu: when he did not receive an award, he stopped speaking Maithili and began saying in Hindi that 'Maithili is the language of dishonest people.'" "Maithilk Avishvasaniyata" recounts that the Maithil tantric Batesh Maharaj owed more than thirty thousand rupees for the printing of his monthly Kamakhya Sandesh. "Tit Lagay Va Karu" recalls that Udaychandra Jha "Vinod" failed to pay 1,575 rupees, taking two hundred books for only 1,100 rupees and neither paying the remainder nor collecting the remaining books.

2

Marmantak—Shabdanubhuti (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume II)

"Mahakalk Vajraghat" in Marmantak—Shabdanubhuti (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume II), written during the coronavirus lockdown on 26 March 2020, recalls events forty-one years earlier: Mishra-ji's entanglement in the misappropriation of bank money, the loss of his job, his mother's deteriorating mental condition and, finally, her death. "Shekhark Avasan" concerns the writer's father. Prabhas-ji, Mukhiya-ji and Batuk Bhai frequently came to visit Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary, yet: "Yes, for the final year he wanted to talk to Pravasi-ji, but it did not prove possible. Even when I asked him, Pravasi-ji never came to see him, right up to the end." This account of his father's death follows the remembrance of his mother's death and was written during lockdown on 27 March 2020. "Agralekhsan Bhet" describes Sharadindu's arrival at Mithila Mihir, although his appointment was officially with Aryavarta, and Bhimnath Jha's belief that this would obstruct his own promotion. Bhimnath wrote a poem entitled "Langur," which wounded Sudhanshu Shekhar and Sharadindu Chaudhary. He felt that Gokul Babu, his junior, had been

promoted above him to assistant editor and that Sudhanshu Shekhar had acquiesced to obtain a job for his son. In reality, Gokul Babu's sponsor was the maternal grandfather of Kumar Saheb, owner of the newspaper and press, while Gokul Babu was related to Kumar Saheb as his mother's sister's husband. Gokul Babu meanwhile abandoned the dhoti-kurta in favour of a safari suit, which Bhimnath found still more intolerable; eventually Bhimnath obtained employment at Mithila University. Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary—Sharadindu's father, whom he called Lalkakka—retired on 2 October 1982, leaving Sharadindu and Dilip (Dilip Singh Jha) to serve as Gokul Babu's personal runabouts. (The politics of Aryavarta, The Indian Nation and Mithila Mihir—and how these institutions collapsed after national newspapers arrived in Patna! We hear that bhang used to be prepared there every afternoon. More memoirs of this kind ought to appear.) "Safalta O Vifaltak Karan" discusses the knowledge of editorial responsibilities and authority that came through contact with Pandit Hiranand Jha Shastri and the late Gajendra Narayan Chaudhary. It also describes the dishonesty of a Maithili writer and Hindi journalist who, at a Sahitya Akademi symposium, credited Deskos and Vinod Kumar Jha with Maithili journalism and belittled the achievements of the Mithila daily by adding, "If it can be called a daily." Baidyanath Vimal is discussed as a representative writer of an age of hypocrisy; Ramanand Jha "Raman," as a critic-editor forever clinging to one support or another.

3

Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume III)

In "Bhumika—Shyampaksha O Hamar Lekhan," he writes, "Almost no one writes what I write. Yes, occasionally I have the good fortune to read a few pieces of a similar kind by Lakshman Jha 'Sagar.'" "Hamar Abhag: Hunak Nahi Dosh" discusses the special issue of the Maithili Academy journal on "Maithiliputra Pradip Prabhunarayan Jha." Sharadindu did all the work, yet Dineshchandra Jha was named as editor, and Sharadindu received just 280 rupees for his labour. "Sampadakiya A Pathakiya Patra" alludes, without naming him, to Ramesh, who used to send readers' letters under the names Abodh and Durbodh Mishra, writing offensive nonsense about Sharadindu and his father because he resented the publication of Shashibodh Mishra "Shashi" in Samay-Sal. Later, on Kedar Kanan's recommendation, Sharadindu published Ramesh in Purvottar Maithil after becoming its editor: "... Now ... he has come down to earth. He writes well." He also remembers publishing a professor's poem in Samay-Sal at Madhukant Jha's request. This poet, he says, does not write nearly as well as Ramesh, producing extremely feeble verse, yet reached the final round for the Sahitya Akademi Award three times. "Maithilik Badalait Swarup" describes Shyam Darihare's order of priorities: first himself, then his book,

and Maithili last. “Paighatvak Akaran Pradarshan Kiek” recalls Kirtinarayan Mishra paying only 9,000 rupees, in front of Mohan Bharadwaj, towards the printing of his book Arthantar and withholding the remaining 3,500 even after all copies were delivered to his home. It also discusses a Sahitya Akademi “Meet the Authors” programme held in the auditorium of its recognised, so-called literary association, the Chetana Samiti. “Kirti Babu spoke in both Hindi and Maithili, asserting that he was an author in both languages. Yet apart from Rajkamal and Yatri, it is plain what standing anyone has achieved in Hindi. … My piercing, pointed question was: ‘You are such an eminent author that the Sahitya Akademi, a premier institution, has arranged today's programme in your honour. Why, then, did you establish the Kirtinarayan Mishra Award in your own name during your lifetime? Were you afraid that nobody would remember you after your death and therefore eager to witness your own publicity while still alive?’ My question disturbed him, and he replied that it had been his family's wish. … Every office-bearer of the Chetana Samiti began protesting, and voices rang out that the award would continue under all circumstances. The reason was that Kirti Babu had arrived with money to increase the award fund for the Chetana Samiti by another one and a half lakh rupees.” This is a firsthand account of the Chetana Samiti extracting money in the name of awards from the person honoured by their name and from that person's family. More such reminiscences should come to light.

“Beimān Hoybak Ghoshana” concerns a Jagdish Mishra of Sahityiki (Sarisab-Pahi), who had asked the well-known writer Ashok to give Sharadindu ten books. Ashok instead handed them to Shiv Kumar Thakur at Vidyapati Bhavan, who sold them and passed on the proceeds. Jagdish Mishra nevertheless announced over the microphone that Sharadindu had sold the books and withheld the money; Ramanand Jha “Raman” reported this accusation to him. This recalls an incident involving an author who called that organisation “Soitiki” until it published one of his books, after which he began calling it “Sahityiki.” “Hamar Abhag: Hunak Saubhagya” describes Bhimnath Jha's instigation of Phoolchandra Mishra “Raman,” and the exclusion of Sharadindu's contribution from a souvenir publication by Satyanarayan Mehta under the aegis of the Chetana Samiti, another supposed literary association (such is the politics of souvenir publications!). “Maithilik Rajnitik Kripa” concerns Ajit Mishra and Aditi Mukherjee of the Central Institute of Indian Languages. At one of its “seminar-cum-workshops,” other people allegedly drew the honoraria payable in Sharadindu's and Madhukant Jha's names. Tejkar Jha, son of Hetukar Jha, conveyed that two Maithili scholars had said in an Institute meeting that Shekhar Prakashan should not receive work under its Translation Mission. Shekhar Prakashan had been assigned the

translation, proofreading, publication and distribution of nine books; but on the advice of one or two sycophants the Institute appointed an editor without consulting Sharadindu, and did not invite him to the publisher-editor meeting. Later, some work went to Narendra Kumar Jha of Novelty. Subsequently, Shri Chandranath Jha, grandson of Pandit Sitaram Jha, told Sharadindu that the Institute had obtained a translation from him and dismissed him with only a small payment. "Irshya Dvesh Nahi—Samanvay Chahi" recounts how Parmeshwar Kapri took books worth five thousand rupees and did not pay, even when Ram Bharos Kapri "Bhramar" asked him to do so. Some disciples of Kedar Kanan acted similarly. It also discusses Taranand Viyogi, who openly uses the phrase "sabh baput" about a particular caste, Brahmins, on Facebook. "... Seventy per cent of the people participating in the very discussions he attends belong to that caste, whose ancestors he keeps attacking. ... I shall acknowledge Viyogi-ji's accomplishment only when he creates and brings forward twenty personalities of his own calibre from his community. Merely stirring people up ..." But Sharadindu also writes that he told Parmeshwar Kapri, "There would be no objection if I tied you to a bamboo pole here and beat you, would there?" "Government" (Vinod Kumar Jha, now satirically styled "Emperor of Poets") and the young poet Balmukund were also present. There can be no justification whatsoever for the remark about tying someone to a bamboo pole and beating him.

4

Sakshat (Baat-Baat Par Baat, Volume IV)

Sharadindu recalls how, while criticising the low standards of the prize process, "... one man abused the mothers and sisters of everyone involved and declared that under no circumstances would he accept a Sahitya Akademi Award or any other award. Yet within barely six months he accepted a prize and was overjoyed. I ask how much that increased his ability and scholarship. What is the point of ranting unnecessarily? Keep fixing things behind the scenes while continuing to heap abuse." Among those who influenced him in Maithili literature he names Kiran, Madhup, Suman, Manipadma, Jayakant Mishra, Prabhas, Gunjan, Mantreshwar, Amar, Jivakant, Govind Babu, Basuki Babu, Pravasi, Rajmohan, Bachcha Thakur, Bhim Babu, Ramdev Babu, Shekhar-ji, Hetukar Babu, Ashok, Shivshankar Srinivas, Ushakiran Khan, Shefalika Verma, Shyamanand Chaudhary, Ranganath Diwakar, Kamalmohan Chunnu, Ajit Azad, Ashok Mehta, Surendra Raut, Raman Kumar Jha, Mukund Mayank and Balmukund. He also observes: "... Journalism is now understood to be a sacrifice. Someone says, 'I've spent eight to ten lakh rupees bringing out my magazine.' Young Lalit Narayan (Mithila Mirror), at his age, says while

reporting, 'I'm wearing my bones away.' Yet by my reckoning he has already become a professional journalist."

He writes: "A publisher is someone who prints other people's books at his own expense, and a printer someone who takes payment for performing a job. A person who does both calls himself both printer and publisher. ... Shekhar Prakashan has performed both functions at both levels. So far as I know, Pustak Bhandar and Granthalaya did the same in the past. ... We have printed a total of fifty-two books entirely at our own expense. We have also published more than three dozen books while meeting half their costs. ..."

Gajendra Thakur

Sharadindu Chaudhary's Memoir-Based Collection of Humour and Satire—Jan Ham Janitahun

If this is a collection of humour and satire, how can it also be memoir literature? Sharadindu himself answers: "Had I known that games just like those of politics were also played in the literary field, I would never have dared set foot in it. But now I am caught, like a fairy who has made the mistake of distributing both milk and fish. I can neither spit it out nor swallow it." He writes further: "... The characters themselves never let me recognise the distinction between humour and satire; their conversations became the subject matter of my writing. ... My journalistic disposition wrote down what it saw, whenever it saw it." Thus the book is demonstrably a collection of memoirs, and the utterances within quotation marks are unseasoned. Some seasoning does occur in the memoirs' headings and outside the quotation marks, but even there only in small measure.

The volume contains eleven memoirs. It became a collection of humour and satire because of the conduct of prize-hungry mainstream Maithili writers, belonging to every caste. The writers appear under their actual literary names, strengthening the book's documentary authenticity. It was published in 2002, but even in 2022 the writers described in it had the same disagreeable habits.

1

And Now: Operation Sahitya Akademi

This memoir consists entirely of dialogue, within quotation marks; hence it contains no added spice. Even the title is not especially embellished: the Sanskrit word atha, equivalent to the opening invocation bismillah,

introduces "Operation Sahitya Akademi." Who are the performers? They are listed below.

Principal performers: Mohan Bharadwaj (now deceased) and Ramanand Jha "Raman."

Their role: To read people's (writers') literary horoscopes, although they spend much of the time playing verbal games with each other.

Supporting performers: One poet of the "sixty and still sprightly" variety; one father-in-law-and-son-in-law pair.

Their role: To make old poets faint with their very first books and to soar through the skies of the Sahitya Akademi.

Technique: To disparage each other's books; however fierce the disputes within Chetana Samiti, power stays with either uncle or nephew.

2

Appeal

Principal performers: Mohan Bharadwaj (now deceased), Basukinath Jha and Ramanand Jha "Raman."

Their role: To seize control of the publication activities of the Maithili Academy and the Chetana Samiti.

Supporting performers: Pathak-ji, Dinesh-ji and Indrakant-ji.

Their roles, respectively: The angry man, the pleasure-seeker and the greedy man.

Technique: A rasping laugh, accompanied by belches of erudition.

3

What a Man He Is, Indeed!

Principal performer: A senior official of an institution.

Role: To have his hands tremble when there is work to be done.

Supporting performers: None.

Technique: Prompted by whispers, to pretend to reform society and rescue the language.

4

I Watched a Shooting

Principal performers: Upendranath Jha "Vyas," Madhukant Jha, Mohan Bharadwaj, Ramanand Jha "Raman," Ramdev Jha, Purnendu Chaudhary and Chandranath Mishra "Amar."

Their role: To take over the literary activities of the Maithili Academy and the Chetana Samiti. The episode of "Angreji Phulk Chitthi." To prevent Somdev, Ramanand Renu and Hansraj from ever coming of age. Bhimnath, Jaymant and Madaneshwar as pupils of the old schoolhouse.

Supporting performers: Jayakant Mishra, Devkant Jha, Kulanand Mishra, Rajmohan Jha, Udaychandra Jha "Vinod," Ashok, Agnipushp, Kedar, Taranand Viyogi, Ramesh and Shivshankar.

Their role: Rajmohan Jha pushing his favourites Ashok, Agnipushp and Kedar forward in order to secure an award before Bhim Bhai; Vijay Kumar Mishra and Vivekanand leaving the field at one word from Sharadu; Virendra Jha making Amresh Pathak drink water; Gokulnath tripping Pravasi up.

Showmen: Chhatranand Singh Jha (Batuk Bhai) and Gopesh-ji.

Behind the scenes (patrons): Ushakiran Khan and Mantreshwar Jha.

Final presenter: Gunjan-ji.

Technique: Mohan Bharadwaj setting Bhim Bhai and Ramdev Jha against each other and himself slipping into the Sahitya Akademi Advisory Committee; Raman-ji shifting material from one storehouse to another, in the Govind Jha felicitation volume and elsewhere, and taking the Chetana Samiti to task.

Pilgrimage sites for the award-hungry (up to 2002): The gurdwara at R-Block in Patna, Shyama Temple in Rajkumar Ganj, Darbhanga, and Prayag on P. C. Banerjee Road.

5

The Health-Protection Award

Inspiration for the programme: Binaca Geetmala.

Announcer: Maithili's Ameen Sayani, Chhatranand; but because he was a Batuk, Ashok was entrusted with the task.

Question: Why was Govind Jha given the Sahitya Akademi Award?

Who did not take part in the quiz? Ramanand Renu, Hansraj, Purnendu Chaudhary and Udaychandra Jha "Vinod," the bridegroom from Rahika.

One-member jury: Suman-ji.

Who boycotted it? Upendranath Jha Vyas, Dr Amresh Pathak and Anand Mishra (because they had not been included in the one-member jury).

Suman-ji's list of sixteen contestants: Sureshwar Jha, Rajmohan Jha, Markandeya Pravasi, Mohan Bharadwaj, Bhimnath Jha, Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary, Jivakant, Shefalika Verma, Kirtinarayan Mishra, Mantreshwar Jha, Agnipushp, Subhashchandra Yadav, Mayanand Mishra, Dr Dhirendra, Somdev and Kedar Kanan.

Welcome song: Buddhinath Mishra and Shanti Suman.

Answer—from Rajmohan Jha: Because Govind Jha might otherwise have written in Hindi (a threat).

After the announcement: Vinod Kumar Jha, Agnipushp and Viyogi dancing joyfully upon Rajmohan Jha's shoulders. Sureshwar Jha: "Since I am the representative, Govind Jha gets the award." Rabindranath Thakur divorcing Mahendra and dancing with Ashok. Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary: "Because Govind Babu admitted that his stories are inferior to those of me and my maternal uncle (Gunjan)." Akku's blood pressure shooting up, followed by his collapse; Vibharani fanning him with the end of her sari, while Kishore, Ramesh and Kumar Shailendra look on jealously. Ashok attracting the attention of Bhimnath, a devotee of Langur.

Suman-ji to Ashok: "Jayakant Babu's days are gone, when everything could be obtained only by money. Nowadays some things can also be accomplished by recommendation."

Ashok: Growing frightened on seeing Umanath Babu, Chetkar Babu and Subhadra Babu, and talking about the Health-Protection Award. Lekhnath Mishra and Dr Basukinath Jha asking whose answer this was. Mohan Bharadwaj praising himself and receiving the Fagua Shiromani Award from Suman-ji. Kulanand Mishra, his vow fulfilled, setting off for Upendra Thakur's house to have his beard trimmed.

6

Blessed Be Lalu-ji, Who Today ...

Pandit Tarakant Jha winning a case in the Patna High Court to restore Maithili to the Bihar Public Service Commission, only for Lalu-ji to drag the matter before the Supreme Court.

7

The Editor's Name ...

A Letter from Fachandi Misra

8

Monologue

Mohan Bharadwaj's lament at not receiving the Sahitya Akademi Award: "Rajmohan Jha, neither Gaurinath, nor Agnipushp, nor Subhashchandra Yadav will be able to protect you."

Disciples drinking bhang: Ramesh, Viyogi and Srinivas, under Ashok's leadership.

Taranand Viyogi to Ashok: "Ashok Bhai, you have managed to set both your presiding preceptors—Mohan Bharadwaj and Rajmohan Jha—at war with each other."

Postscript: Later, despite a devastatingly fulsome review of Vidyanath Jha "Vidit"'s novel Viplavi Besara—"devastating" here a synonym for an ingratiating, bed-breaking panegyric—Vidit still did not secure the award for him.

9

The Husband of the White-Collared

Accounts of the hawala, urea, uniform, animal-husbandry, tar and other scams.

10

Had I Known

An opportunity to observe, identify and make fun of the writers of mainstream Maithili literature.

11

Plato's Dream, India and the Politics of Celibacy

Reflections on the philosopher-king in Plato's Republic and the conduct of unmarried people today.

Gajendra Thakur

Sharadindu Chaudhary's Three Satirical Collections—Bar Ajagut Dekhal, Gobarganesh and Kariya Kakkak Koramin

Bar Ajagut Dekhal appeared in 2005, Gobarganesh in 2011, and Kariya Kakkak Koramin in 2016. All three are satirical volumes belonging to the Kariya Kakka series, differing in two ways from Chaudhary's memoir literature. Kariya Kakka is the embodiment of a greed one can recognise, but not a person's real name. In some pieces Kariya Kakka disappears altogether; in others, real-life figures bearing their own names force their way in despite the author's deliberate efforts to keep them out. Of the three, however, the author explicitly describes Bar Ajagut Dekhal as a memoir. In its introductory "Mukti Paybak Prayatna," he writes: "What I could not do, what I could not even think of doing, but saw happening—that is what Bar Ajagut Dekhal contains."

1

Bar Ajagut Dekhal

What Are You Churning?

"... Our Maithili ... has been compelled to become the servant of fathers-in-law and sons-in-law ... and has become a source of income for certain social activists."

Darshan–Sudarshan

"... Come, to the dwelling of the great poet Vidyapati at the Chetana Samiti ...

"... 'Who is this playwright from Nepal?'

"'It is Mahendra Malangiya, sir.'

"... 'Give this year's Chetana Award to that playwright.'

"... 'But there are writers senior to him ...'

"'We have to give it to somebody, whether young or old ...'"

"'The poets' conference ought to be discontinued altogether. Nobody attends at that time anyway. ... If it is to be held, then raise the money. ... The Maithili Academy promised five thousand in the name of a poets' conference, but paid only two thousand. How could there be anything left? A deficit was there from the beginning. ... A wall has been built around the printed books ...'"

"... 'Don't run away. Yatri-ji founded it and then fled. Today his photograph hangs on the wall, but several people claim to be its founder ...'"

2

Gobarganesh

The Signboard Is on the Thatch; I Am Sleeping on the Cot

"In the courtyard of the Maithili Academy. You too are singing the very same Fagua. Both lecture series have made their own advisers the lecturers, and they are getting some third person to edit all the books." (This is directed at Ashok, Taranand Viyogi and Mohan Bharadwaj.)

Meanwhile

"'The Sahitya Akademi conducted just such an experiment: even someone who owned a hotel could become a member of the advisory committee. ... There is a great deal of political manoeuvring in Patna too. The Writers' Association would not have to go begging for honours. ... The Maithili Lekhak Sangh ... nothing but felicitations, with neither a pulse of life nor a roar. Only a quarrelsome person's cry in the wilderness of deprivation.'"

Golaisi—"That Is to Say"

The work of criticism that could not be kept on its feet by the crutches of proverbs, and that even the books Akhiyasal, Besahal and Bhajaral (Ramanand Jha "Raman"'s volumes of half-criticism) could not sell—surely the standard by which to judge it is Golaisi alone!

CD Review

"'Raman-ji, you must go there; he is helpless ... To activate Bharadwaj-ji's pen, Ashok and Taranand Viyogi, their hands folded in supplication, were begging the owner Nachiketa for five litres of engine oil. But Munshi Ramlochan told them that when it was given to him once (alluding to Mohan Bharadwaj's accepting or securing a Prabodh Award while serving on its selection committee), such an uproar broke out that if they gave it to him again they would not even be able to show themselves to the people of Mithila. ... It will be a mixture of Jivakant's Jogira and Amar's Biraha, a spectacle of Bhimnath's sweets and Ramdev's by-products, accompanied by the jingling of Panna, Indira, Nita, Sushila and Veena. ... To seize Mantreshwar-ji's arm, to flourish and blossom. But the longings went unfulfilled. ... I went to Nar Indra ... but he turned out to be something else again. ... He has no leisure from diamonds and emeralds. ... This is Agnipushp; adorn yourself with him. ... Kunal, Sukant and Saketanand ... they are homosexual. ... Vidit-ji ... he himself is a lover of pleasure. He will

perform evening devotions with Pravasi-ji and sing duets with Thakurain ...'"

"Guest Indrakant Jha ... Jha-ji Virendra ... a direct connection to the vice-president of Nepal ... Pandit Yoganand Jha ... Baidyanath Mishra, Ganesh Jha ... they are humiliating me ..."

"Surendranath, Kedar Kanan and Ramesh were shouting under Bachcha Thakur's leadership. ... Then Ajit (Azad) began speaking: 'Wherever you are, send an SMS and help this "government" as we helped confer that status, through SMS messages, on Rajmohan Jha and Premshankar Singh.'"

3

Kariya Kakkak Koramin

Classification of the Granary of Intellect

Excepting writers of the two gotras—Bharadwaj and Raman—of the genealogical register, since they belong to the category of Maithili's pathologists.

A Beautiful Child Born of a "Live-in Relationship"

The poisonous-insect-like literary public-relations officer of a well-known Patna committee attended this ceremony too and played such politics with the Nepalese literary community that, deeply offended, its members took back with them the contribution in Nepalese rupees they had brought in their wallets.

Gender Examination of the "Government"

"You made a person of Mithila dressed as a man into your 'government'" (an allusion to Vinod Kumar Jha), "but he could not perform a single task worthy of a man. At one time he passed his days as Acharya Arishtanemi's wife-like attendant; now, having become Draupadi in an association, he is a fortunate married woman."

The Art of Writing Satire

Acharya Arishtanemi is also discussed here.

"Lutan ... became a courtier of Acharya Arishtanemi (Chandranath Mishra 'Amar') and looked after the arrangements of the stages ..."

A Child in the Lap, an Uproar in the Town

"'Is this not precisely the joke? The old government, after cheating and cheating, fell headlong from the tree of power but never divulged the secret. And now look: the new government is singing the very same tune.'"

The Results of Award Science

Yoganand remarked teasingly: "'If you get Doctor Saheb to release your book but refuse to recognise the dominance of the gentleman from Mishra Tola and his Ojha-ji, how will you understand why an apple falls to the ground headfirst from a tree?' ..."

"While practising the veena, let them also try to please Mishra-ji and Ojha-ji by addressing them as 'idam rase, idam gudde' ..."

106. A Comprehensive View of Ram Bharos Kapri "Bhramar"

Abstract
Ram Bharos Kapri "Bhramar" accorded dignity to the proletariat. This was especially significant when Mahendra Malangiya and caste-bound theatre were inserting expressions such as sholkan and raar into slapstick plays. How can a director decide to stage a play unless it moves the reader? And does finding a play rewarding to read mean insisting only on its literary, as opposed to theatrical, qualities?

Keywords: Bharos · Kapri · Bhramar · comprehensive · perspective · drama · Malangiya

A Comprehensive View of Ram Bharos Kapri "Bhramar"

If a play does not stir someone who reads it, how can a director decide to stage it? And does enjoying a play in print mean demanding only its readable qualities? Conversely, does a writer whose drama is casteist and trades in "slapstick humour" thereby become an advocate of theatre's performative qualities? In the twenty-first century, Malangiya-ji calls an oppressed community "raar" in Okar Angank Barahmasa. Several decades later his terminology has improved to the extent that he now calls the group the "lower class." This improvement is welcome, but after so long it is very little. How could Malangiya have continued rehearsing his caste-based syntax and constructions mixed with broken Hindi without introducing his artificial conceptions of the bhagta and the lower classes? He cleverly tries to conceal this fact and consequently remains unable to rise above mediocrity. He wishes to give his dramatic narratives a purpose, but has not developed the capacity to do so. Vishnu Sharma's Panchatantra contains good tales, yet needlessly targets Shudras and women; Narayana Pandit therefore had to recast the material in Hitopadesha. Theatre directors, too, ought to rewrite language of this kind to arrive at a vocabulary fit for the stage.

Bhramar's dignified language honours the dignity of people.

First, however, a look at Bhramar's short-short stories:

Tora Sange Jaybau Re Kujba (1987)

This collection contains twelve short-short stories.

The first, "Bhagjogani," opens powerfully. The protagonist Abhi is astonished to see Rekha, the glamorous young woman, worried about household life. She is unhappy with the family and society that sent her off

to Kathmandu at the age of eighteen or nineteen to earn money. Her husband, living in Banaras, depended on her earnings, while her businessman friend Shekhar paid for her fashionable expenses. Yet the ending of the story is weak.

"Andharme Bhotiaayal Ekta Sipahi" is an excellent story, a sketch of Ganesh and people like him: "A daura, trousers and cap borrowed from our sharecropper at Haripur, Baba's old shoes on his feet, and spectacles with one broken arm tied in place by a string."

"Bhotiaayal Batak Batohi," "Norak Bunn" and "Asakk" portray the thoughts and dejection of individuals well. But the way the pain of the proletariat is conveyed in "Matik Darad" is extraordinary.

"Manahsthitik Dansh" is astonishingly constructed. A young woman's husband works night duty, as a security guard. She is frail. Her father-in-law enters her home, although she learns this only afterwards. On the first night she is so terrified that she cannot even tell whether she has had sexual intercourse or merely dreamed it. The story progresses, displaying further technical distinctions; yet, as it approaches its conclusion, it grows weaker.

"Tis" is the story of a girl in the tenth standard. She wants to make something of herself, but ...

Just as "Tis" is Gita's story, "Mausi" is the story of an aunt who is leaving today, but whom nobody can remove from their heart.

In "Ancharme Barkha Bunni," the protagonist thinks amidst drops of rain. A terrible downpour will destroy the standing paddy. Saraswati, Sunita, Gita. Saraswati did not find a good marital home; the protagonist must seek a prospective bridegroom for Gita. Memories ... amidst the raindrops.

"Pank" is the story of a modern Rekha, but it drifts without purpose. The title story, "Tora Sange Jaybau Re Kujba," likewise fails to illuminate relations between women and men, much as "Pank" does. Its flashbacks keep raising hopes, but the reader remains thirsty, and that thirst grows more acute when the storyteller ends with lines as powerful as these:

> *I shall go with you, O hunchback,*
> *What happiness it will be—*
> *Riding an elephant, we shall travel the world ...*

Bhramar's Plays

If folktales and proverbs are not collected through fieldwork, the result is what we find in Malangiya's plays. One may record a proverb current in one community—"Ten Brahmins have ten stomachs; ten raars have

one"—but fail to record the counter-proverb in another: "Ten Brahmins have one stomach …" Mahendra Narayan Ram writes that folktales know no caste distinctions, but how could Malangiya-ji accept that? The bhagta also keeps appearing in his stories. The fundamental reason that such features become inseparable from Malangiya's drama is his inherited conception of caste superiority. His plays generally string together a number of scenes, each stretching to about two and a half pages. Until the final two or three scenes, he follows his old method: a supposedly "lower-caste" language of his own invention makes the upper-caste audience laugh, while the bhagta's broken Hindi supplies pseudo-humour. In the last two or three scenes he tries to make the dramatic story purposeful, but cannot bring it off. In "Pachhpaniya Maithili," Subhash Chandra Yadav writes: "Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman' had jotted in his notebook: 'The Brahmin says, I am sleeping; the Solhkan says, I am a Brahmin. What can I say about what I am?' The contempt towards the Solhkan expressed in this note is nothing other than a linguistic expression of caste animosity and hatred." In "Ram Bharos Kapri 'Bhramar': Thought, Sensibility and Consciousness" [Videha, issue 370], Chandresh writes: "First, Nepalese Maithili plays were not even treated as plays. Second, in the theatre performed by MINAP, only the plays of one particular individual were staged. To break that dominant practice and awaken the prevailing mentality, at one time he placed particular emphasis on writing drama." That particular individual was Malangiya. During Nepal's monarchy, Malangiya failed to live up to his commitment as a writer: he wrote plays politically favourable to those in power and took care that audiences laughed only at the proletariat, never at the rulers. In "The Historical Context of the Play Murda" [Ramesh Ranjan, Murda, year 2069], Professor Parmeshwar Kapri writes: "Dr Dhirendra and Malangiya … kept themselves apart from politics. Thus no trace of political conflict appears in their writing or creative practice." In the same essay, writing about Ramesh Ranjan and Malangiya, Kapri says: "Although Ramesh-ji spent a long time around Malangiya, working alongside him in theatre, the truth is that no shadow or impression of Malangiya appears to have fallen upon his work. Another fact is that he created this important work while away from Malangiya and the institution associated with him. What I mean is that he wrote it [Murda, a play, in Vikram Samvat 2050] precisely when he had separated himself from Malangiya and MINAP and committed himself to his own resolve. It is worth remembering that MINAP has still not staged it."

Under these circumstances Bhramar made Maithili drama a medium of dialogue and fashioned for it a language that was not insulting to the proletariat but affirmed their dignity. Although living under a monarchy and being a citizen of Nepal (Malangiya worked in Nepal but was an

Indian citizen), he brought political subjects into his creative practice through folk ballads.

In "Bhaiya, Aelai Apan Soraj," Man 1 and Man 2 oppose the feudal lord's demand for unpaid labour, while a song rises from offstage:

Every day they come to make us cut thatch,

Those seven hundred Musahars ...

"In every one of the seven hundred Musahar homes, only goats are reared." Dina and Bhadri enter as mendicants, singing the song of King Bhartrihari.

Similarly, "Mahishasur Murdabad" is a one-actor play in which Man 1 can perform both his own part and the voices heard from offstage. Kill one and many more spring up to stand in his place. The character's work therefore remains unfinished, and he does not yet wish to mount the gallows.

Lok Natya: Jat Jatin (2007), a research work, bears witness to his commitment to fieldwork. That is why he is called the Shakespeare of the folk-theatre tradition of Nepalese Maithili.

107. Narendra Jha: Poetry and Literary Assessment

Abstract

The two forces have met in conflict. At times she gathers up her tresses, at times lets them loose; sometimes she covers her body, sometimes reveals it. Her once-steady eyes have grown restless. A blush has spread across the budding rise of her breasts. Her feet are quick, and her heart seems unsettled.

Keywords: Narendra · poetry · literary · assessment · Mithila · did · restless

Editorial

Narendra Jha

Nimble Feet, a Restless Heart
Childhood and youth have met in sight; the hosts of both have come into conflict.
Now she binds her hair, now lets it fall; now she veils her body, now reveals it.
Eyes once steady have become unsteady; the budding breasts have taken on a blush.
Nimble feet and a restless heart; desire has awakened in her joyful eyes.
Vidyapati says: Take heed! The maiden's body has been struck by the five arrows of love.
[*Childhood and youth have met, and their two armies are locked in conflict.*
At times she binds up her tresses (hair), at times spreads them loose; sometimes she covers her body, sometimes uncovers it.
Her once-steady eyes have become restless; a blush has spread across the budding rise of her breasts.
Her feet are nimble and her heart appears unsettled. Manasija (Kamadeva, the god of love) has awakened in her delighted eyes.
Vidyapati says: Exercise restraint (avadhan, vigilance or self-control). All five arrows of Manasija—that is, Kamadeva—have struck the maiden's body.]
(Vidyapati, the great poet predating Jyotirishwar.)

Narendra Jha wrote his autobiographical statement under the title "Chapal Charan Chit Chanchal Bhan" (Antika, January–June 2009).

In 1934 an earthquake struck Mithila. For several years before it, something called sahasra-badhni had been observed, and people suspected that something untoward would happen.

In that earthquake Narendra Jha's father's house collapsed. The family established a new homestead on the southern bank of the ancestral pond,

which their forebears had excavated. Narendra Jha was born at that new homestead on 22 September 1934, in the village of Tarauni.

He then mentions Shrotriya Brahmins of the Karamhe lineage during the reign of Shiva Singh. This is factually mistaken if Shrotriya is taken to mean a subcaste of Brahmins. Certainly someone versed in the Vedas may be called a shrotriya, as throughout India and Nepal even today.

Maharaja Harisingh Deva belonged to Mithila's Karnata dynasty. In Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varna-Ratnakara, was Harisingh Deva a hero or a king? He was born in 1294 and ascended the throne in 1307. Defeated by Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq in 1324–25, he fled to Nepal. As the formal initiator of Mithila's panji system among Brahmins, Kayasthas and Kshatriyas, he first appointed Gunakar Jha for Maithil Brahmins, Shankardatta for Karna Kayasthas and Vijayadatta for Kshatriyas. At Harisingh Deva's instigation —he was descended from Nanyadeva, who had established the Karnata dynasty in Shaka 1009, "nandaid shunyam shashi shaka varshe" (Shaka 1019) ...—the scholars of Mithila decided in Shaka 1248, or 1326 CE, to begin the panji register in its present form. Later, in 1760, certain intellectually self-indulgent individuals obtained orders from Maharaja Madhav Singh of Mithila to have the genealogists compile branch-books in the currently used arrangement. Subsequently, a new Brahmin subcaste called "Shrotriya" emerged in Mithila in the genealogical registers (sometimes dated to Shaka 1600, or 1678 CE, though in fact it appeared after Madhav Singh, around 1800 CE). [See Mithilak Panji Prabandh, Volumes 1 and 2 (Genome Mapping and Genealogical Mapping, 2009 and 2012, Gajendra Thakur, genealogists Vidyanand Jha and Nagendra Kumar Jha).]

Narendra's father, a devotee of Radha and Krishna, wanted to build a temple on the bank of the pond. But the western estate office at Raghopur objected (under Cornwallis's Permanent Settlement, the Darbhanga Raj had obtained its position as a zamindari estate; its holders were in fact landlords, mistakenly styled kings or maharajas by uninformed people; under the Permanent Settlement's zamindars were numerous appointed collection agents and gomastas, their offices known as deorhis). Litigation followed, in which Narendra's eldest paternal uncle Bhagirath Jha and a family servant, Ganaura, led the struggle. His Vaishnava spiritual teacher would not allow anyone to fish in the pond; when a fisherman slipped in secretly, the teacher himself entered the water and drove him away.

Narendra Jha completed his Intermediate in Commerce at Darbhanga in 1954 and then earned a B.Com. For a time he worked in Darbhanga with Lakshman Jha, the celebrated Lakhan Jha, on matters concerning Mithila and Maithili. There is also discussion of Suniti Kumar Chatterji and the Mithila Research Institute: Chatterji's unbecoming treatment of Mithila's

Sanskrit scholars, Lakshman Jha's reproach, and Chatterji's explanation. Later, living in Calcutta (now Kolkata), Narendra began preparing for the Chartered Accountancy examinations in August 1956 and qualified as a Chartered Accountant in January 1966. After spells in Calcutta and Delhi he settled permanently in Patna in 1975. Meanwhile he married Panna Jha on 3 July 1959. In 1964 his wife graduated with a BA (Honours) in Psychology from Bihar University; she joined him in Calcutta in 1965. Following heart surgery in 1997–98, he felt that perhaps he had not worked actively enough for Mithila and Maithili, so he began writing essays and taking part in Bharati, the Maithili programme of All India Radio, Patna. The following books by Narendra and his wife had appeared by the time of writing and, with his permission, were made available as PDFs in Videha's book repository at http://www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm (with the exception of Psycho Social Stress and Schizophrenia, 2003, which could not be obtained).

Narendra Jha

Mithilak Arthik Vikas (2000); Mithilak Janpadiya Vikas (2005); Mithila Me Jal-Sansadhan O Prabandhan (2006); Vikas O Arthatantra (2008); Paribhraman (2012); Arthatantra O Bhrashtachar (2012); Smriti (2013); Mithila Rising (2014); Chapal Charan Chit Chanchal Bhan (2021).

Panna Jha

Psycho Social Stress and Schizophrenia (2003); Anubhuti (short-short story collection, 2009); Anushilan (essay collection, 2012); Abhilasha (short-short story collection, 2021).

He calls Patna's Maithili organisation, the "Chetana Samiti," the "Achetana Samiti"—the Unconscious Committee—for its activities warrant the name. He regrets leaving Calcutta, which he considers the place where the work of Mithila and Maithili was accomplished. He remembers Prabodh Babu, Babu Saheb Chaudhary, Sukhdev Thakur and Shrikant Mandal, none of whom is still alive. Virendra Mallik has turned away from his fiery Maithili writing and become absorbed in ritual. How much can Ramlochan Thakur achieve single-handedly? ("Chapal Charan Chit Chanchal Bhan" was written in 2009; Ramlochan Thakur has since died as well.) Narendra brought his wife Panna Jha and his younger brothers Agnipushp and Kunal from Calcutta to Patna, where hardly any work for Maithili takes place. Panna Jha remained engaged in the association's work (she too has now died); Agnipushp has been struggling to bring out the magazine Samvad, while Kunal has been producing serials of Maithili plays. Narendra does not believe a separate Mithila state will be created in his lifetime.

Note: The biographical account printed in Narendra Jha's book did not give his mother's name, so it could not be included here.

Postscript: After Videha's special issue on Narendra Jha appeared electronically, Shri Kunal had a copy printed and presented it to Narendra Jha. Similarly, when the special issue on Kedarnath Chaudhary appeared, Shri Arvind Gupta supplied Kedarnath Chaudhary with both the link to the Videha e-journal and a printed copy of the special issue. Thanks to everyone.

108. Ramanand Jha 'Raman': His Literary Work and Its Limits

Abstract

Ramanand Jha 'Raman': His Literary Work and Its Limits—An Editorial Reappraisal. I shall take no pleasure in praise from someone incapable of appreciating the merits of this book. If a crowd of blind people praises a painting, how does that increase the painter's distinction? Let people criticise this book by pointing out its faults.

Keywords: Ramanand · literary work · limits · demarcation · practice · writing · also

Ramanand Jha 'Raman': His Literary Work and Its Limits—An Editorial Reappraisal

> *"I shall take no pleasure in praise from someone incapable of appreciating the merits of this book. If a crowd of blind people praises a painting, how does that increase the painter's distinction? Let people criticise this book by pointing out its faults. Learned people are certainly pleased when their attention is drawn to factual errors they have made unknowingly." — Udayanacharya, concluding remarks on criticism in Ātmatattvaviveka.*

Read together, the seventeen contributions received for this special issue—from introductory essays and two extended reviews of books (Akhiyasal and Hiaol) to interviews, reminiscences and evaluative essays—make one thing clear. Raman Ji's place in Maithili literature is beyond dispute. Yet the value of this special issue will be fully realised only if, alongside praise, it identifies the limitations that recur in the contributions themselves and emerge repeatedly from Raman Ji's own practice of criticism. I bring these limitations together under four headings below: first, the limits of his critical method, chiefly as revealed in the review of Akhiyasal; second, those arising from the chapter-by-chapter review of Hiaol; third, limitations concerning his personality, literary achievement and institutional evaluation; and fourth, points of editorial and stylistic disagreement, as well as dissent among readers.

Part One: Akhiyasal and the Fundamental Limitations of the Critical Method

The extensive review of Akhiyasal (1995), Contribution 4, is the most systematically organised and unsparing of the seventeen contributions. The latter half of that review is devoted entirely to Akhiyasal's limitations,

weaknesses and methodological difficulties, enumerating eight distinct "limitations" in order.

(a) Criticism Without Access to the Text

The gravest limitation is that, in almost every early essay, the critic himself acknowledges the "unavailability" of the original work. On Chandraprabha he writes: "It has not been possible to study and analyse Chandraprabha properly; the principal reason is its unavailability." On Trilochan Jha: "Very little material is available." On Yaduvar: "Very little research has been carried out on Yaduvar so far." On the forgotten Janardan Jha: "Works that may have appeared in journals and periodicals are no longer generally accessible." A profound contradiction arises here: if the original work was not available to the critic himself, on what basis could an aesthetic evaluation of it be made? In many places the criticism in effect depends on secondary sources—Jayakant Mishra's history of Maithili literature, Karunakant Jha's research dissertation and quotations supplied by other critics. From the standpoint of text-centred criticism, this is a fundamental weakness: criticism without the text.

(b) Unstable Standards of Value and Internal Contradictions

Ramanand Jha praises in one essay the very opposite of what he regards as the highest virtue in another. In discussing Ganganand Singh, the female characters of Chandragrahan, Lalit and Dhirendra, he treats sensitivity to contemporary reality, engagement with the surrounding milieu and the representation of the life of an age as supreme values. Yet he praises Vyas's stories precisely because they are not particularly affected by contemporary life and remain untouched by the distortions of a changing age. This is a direct self-contradiction: involvement with reality is sometimes a virtue, and at other times its absence is a virtue. Similarly, Harimohan Jha's humour is assigned a lower value because it does not "stimulate thought," whereas Madhup's songs are assigned a higher value for their "immediate effect upon the heart" and the pleasure they give—even though songs, too, commonly depend on the immediacy of feeling rather than intellectual deliberation. A self-contradictory, purpose-driven composition such as Kobar-git is justified on the argument that "society is greater than the individual." From the perspective of Kshemendra's theory of propriety, however, a composition that runs counter to the inner self constitutes a fundamental rupture of emotional propriety; here the critic cannot provide theoretical clarity. This instability arises because Ramanand Jha does not adopt any single declared theoretical commitment: according to the occasion, his approach becomes impressionistic, sociological, biographical or formalist. Such methodological eclecticism gives him flexibility on one side, but on the other makes his judgements unpredictable and inconsistent.

(c) The Absence of Theoretical Terminology

Although concepts from Indian poetics—rasa, dhvani, vyañjanā and aucitya, among others—are implicitly present in Ramanand Jha's criticism, he does not employ these classical paradigms anywhere as explicitly articulated analytical instruments. Words such as "suggested," "communication" and "emotion-based" occur, but there is no systematic application of the theories of Anandavardhana, Abhinavagupta, Kuntaka, Kshemendra or Bhatta Nayaka, nor even a sustained invocation of these theorists by name. Western theories likewise receive neither explicit discussion nor considered application. The result is an ambivalent position: on one hand, this theoretical economy makes the criticism readable and accessible to a general journal readership; on the other, it produces a lack of academic depth. The criticism is descriptive and evaluative, but less fully theoretical and analytical.

(d) Narrowness of Perspective: Male-Centrism and Caste-Centrism

Of the twenty-five essays, twenty-four are devoted to male authors and only one—to Harilata—to a woman writer. Even there, the discussion of Harilata remains largely confined to Vaishnava devotion. It neglects the socially critical possibilities of her struggle to learn letters in secret against the prohibitions associated with child marriage, widowhood and female education. Women generally appear as characters or sources of inspiration, less often as independent authors, editors or critics. Similarly, almost all the writers discussed come from one particular social stratum. Dalit, most-backward and minority voices from Mithila, along with the unnamed creators of its folk traditions, remain almost entirely absent from this parallel history.

(e) Inconsistency of Compilation and Questions of Textual Authenticity

These twenty-five essays were written independently between 1972 and 1989, for different magazines and journals, on different occasions and with different readerships in mind. Bringing them together as a "book" creates an inherent unevenness: some essays are centred on individuals, others on particular works, genres or literary tendencies. No consistent theoretical framework unites them all. The introduction, account of method and conclusion that one would expect in a deliberately planned book are missing. The authenticity of the passages of poetry and prose quoted in it is also left in doubt, since the critic himself acknowledges that many works are scattered across journals and no longer available; comparison with and verification against the original texts was therefore often nearly impossible. The rigorous textual criticism, manuscript study and

publication history required to substantiate claims such as "first" and "original" remain undeveloped in this early work.

(f) The Incomplete Theorisation of a Parallel-History Paradigm

Finally, the most fundamental limitation is that Ramanand Jha practises the idea of a parallel history without clearly formulating it as a theory. His distinction between "two categories of literary figures" comes closest to doing so, but remains a supplement to, rather than an alternative or a challenge to, the mainstream canon represented by Jayakant Mishra's literary history. Time and again the critic accepts Jayakant Mishra as an authoritative foundation and depends on his information, whereas the real responsibility of a parallel history is to question the foundational assumptions of the mainstream canon itself.

Part Two: Limitations Emerging from the Chapter-by-Chapter Review of Hiaol

The review of Hiaol (2012), Contribution 16, is the longest and most methodical essay in this special issue. It examines all seventeen chapters separately by three measures: Indian poetics, Western literary theory and the Videha perspective of parallel history. Here, too, each chapter's achievements are set beside its limitations. Some of the main points are gathered below.

Limitations Concerning the Study of the Maithili Language

The opening chapter rests principally on evidence furnished by Western scholars—Colebrooke, Beames, Hoernle and Grierson—while indigenous grammatical thinking before Dinbandhu Jha is left almost untouched. Consequently, the essay itself depends on the very colonial epistemological source-material that it criticises: a familiar self-contradiction in postcolonial discourse. In determining standard Maithili, it also leaves unanswered the question of the social rights of other dialectal forms—and, more fundamentally, of the power structures through which a standard is established.

Limitations in the Chapters on Ramanath Jha and Kiran Ji

The collection's longest chapter, "Ramanath Jha and the Mithila Language," is structurally loose. The substance of six independent essays—counter-criticism, biography, the antiquity of the language, debates over script, standardisation and language management—is crowded beneath a single heading. Despite a declared commitment to balance, its tone sometimes becomes less a critical examination of a life than a defensive tribute. Kiran Ji's refutation of an opinion is described as "emotional," yet the author's own vocabulary for the opposing side is not entirely free of

emotion. In the chapter "Kiran Ji as a Counter-Critic," moreover, quotations are selected one-sidedly to demonstrate contradictions; passages in which Kiran Ji may have corrected himself or revised his views have not been sought out. Differences of opinion over forty years of writing may indicate intellectual development, not merely contradiction.

Limitations in the Reading of Kanyadan and in the Chapter on Yatri's Language

"Let Kanyadan Be Read Through the Eyes of the Neglected Woman," regarded as the collection's most challenging chapter from the standpoint of feminist rereading, is itself limited by its unanswered succession of questions. "Who is responsible for this?" is asked repeatedly, but the author does not give a judgement supported by evidence. The promise to read through the eyes of the neglected woman ultimately remains suspended in an interrogative posture. Nor is there a rasa-theoretical examination of the humour of Kanyadan, the principal source of its popularity; at points the rereading turns into an indictment. Likewise, the chapter on Yatri's language borrows all four stylistic instruments from Western sources, while their relationship to Indian poetics is only indicated. A systematic comparison of selection and deviation with Kuntaka's six kinds of vakratā could have completed the bridge between East and West; that opportunity was missed.

Limitations Concerning the Neglected Poets Lakshmipati Singh and Manmohan Jha

In the chapter on Lakshmipati Singh, the author himself admits that he has been able to "gather only a few" of the scattered poems. This honest admission deserves praise, but it also means that the conclusions rest on a limited sample and that the legitimacy of generalisation remains doubtful. Certain natural symbols are read as direct political metaphors, yet these interpretations are not everywhere corroborated by the poems' internal structures or by evidence from other poems. The chapter on Manmohan Jha is the shortest in the collection, and its very brevity is its chief limitation: it announces a concern with a "neglected aspect," but the analysis remains at the level of plot summary. Having been written on the tenth day after the writer's death, its tender commemorative tone outweighs critical detachment.

In an overall judgement, the reviewer of Hiaol himself writes at the end: "The full method of a parallel current is reached when marginalised voices speak for themselves. In Hiaol, people have spoken on behalf of the margins; the margins have been allowed to speak much less." This one sentence succinctly encompasses the limitations of the entire collection.

Part Three: Limitations Concerning Personality, Literary Work and Institutional Evaluation

The Gap Between Dedication and Results

Praveen Kumar Jha's essay, Contribution 15, is the most outspoken voice in this special issue. After a long passage of praise, he declares, "But, but, but!" and writes plainly: "Contribution is one thing; substantial contribution is another." Despite having held important positions over so many years in institutions such as Chetna Samiti and the Maithili Writers' Association, and despite his considerable intellectual abilities, Raman Ji does not emerge as having played any clearly decisive role in the struggle to secure Maithili's inclusion in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution. Nor, despite his involvement in an organisation such as Chetna Samiti, does any major achievement in Maithili education clearly appear that can be attributed directly to his leadership. The author specifies that he is questioning not Raman Ji's dedication but the results of that dedication. How much time someone has devoted and how hard they have worked is one matter; what concrete benefits that work has brought to the language, education, literary people and society is another, more important matter. The essay also refers to allegations and controversies concerning his tenure at Chetna Samiti and the promotion of books and literary activities, as well as criticism that diplomatic engagement with the government and ruling establishment was prioritised over confrontation. The writer adds, however, that an independent inquiry would be needed before treating these allegations as conclusive truth.

Satire on Silence

Dr Dhanakar Thakur's essay, Contribution 11, is predominantly satirical in style, but conceals a sharp implication. Calling Raman Ji Chetna Samiti's "Guru Dronacharya," the author compares the silence of Chetna Samiti—and therefore of Raman Ji—on the question of a Mithila state with the episode in which the teacher Dronacharya kept his eyes closed. "For Chetna Samiti, the question of a Mithila state is like a red rag to a bull": this line states plainly that the institution and its leading literary pillar prefer silence on a politically sensitive issue.

Questions of Impartiality and the Incompleteness of the Register

The observation by Rajlin Thakur quoted in Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra's essay, Contribution 12, is explicit: "Raman Ji is both a person dear to him and a good critic, but he has one failing: he highlights the work of a limited section of society more than that of others, and at such points he cannot remain impartial." Naronarayan Mishra's memoir-like essay, Contribution 13, likewise points out that the register of literary figures it

presents does not include the name of an activist playwright such as Babusaheb Chaudhary. That absence silently raises a question about selectivity in Raman Ji's work of registration.

Part Four: Editorial and Stylistic Limitations and Disagreements Among Readers

An Admission of Methodological Indiscipline

Kumar Rahul's essay, Contribution 6, is the most direct on this point. Beginning, "I can at least delineate his limitations," he writes plainly that Raman Ji, as a learned critic, does not appear to follow any settled or circumscribed rules in his criticism; instead, he is sometimes influenced by a single element and delivers his judgement on that basis. In places, Raman Ji deals with a work or an author in a few words, almost like a brief note, and devotes more space to what he himself wishes to say. Quoting Hudson's view—that the task of criticism is not merely to determine what is right or wrong in a work but to establish definite standards—the writer acknowledges that a number of Raman Ji's essays do not fully meet this theoretical test.

Unevenness in Editorial Work

Pradeep Bihari's essay, Contribution 14, says explicitly at one point that Raman Ji's editing of the magazine Ghar-Bahar does not display the skill evident in his analytical and research-based books. On the writing of introductions and editorials, he observes: "The intellectual urgency a writer ought to possess for these two kinds of writing is visible in Raman Ji in many places, but not everywhere. In some places he has been one-sided." The essay also notes that, while he receives much praise for his service to literature, he is also subjected to criticism and disparagement; how seriously he considers these responses cannot be determined from the expression on his face.

Disagreements over Facts and Interpretations

In Kirtinath Jha's review of Vivarta, Contribution 10, one explicit disagreement is recorded. When Raman Ji describes Maithili magazines and journals as "fully sensitive and responsible" towards the freedom movement, the reviewer comments, "But it is difficult to say whether this view commands universal agreement on the subject." Ajit Kumar Jha's essay, Contribution 5, expresses still clearer dissent from Raman Ji's rereading of Kanyadan: the critic's reasoning appears one-sided, and Raman Ji's division of Harimohan Jha's readers into three categories omits a fourth—readers who regard Raman Ji's own writing as an attack on Mithila's culture. As the essay puts it, "Raman Ji has not discussed the

fourth category in his article." Hitnath Jha's essay, Contribution 17, also registers a clear disagreement. Referring to Raman Ji's attack on literary politics in the preface to his collection of keynote addresses, the reviewer writes: "This was a forum, and for a book of this kind, I do not think it appropriate … Before launching an attack, there should also be room for reform."

The Shortcomings in Ramanand Jha 'Raman's Critical Historiography from Ashish Anchinhar's Perspective

The central insistence of Ashish Anchinhar's essay is that writing literary history does not mean merely collecting books, listing names or taking a book published later as the point of origin. For him, the historian's first qualification is a "sense of history": an impartial understanding of the sequence of events, publications, influence, earlier experiments, sources and credit. By this measure he finds several shortcomings, particularly in the preface Ramanand Jha 'Raman' wrote for Dharmendra Vihwal's book Vyomak Ohipar.

1. The Absence of Historical Awareness

Anchinhar's foremost objection is that Raman Ji has forgotten his "sense of history" in this instance. In Anchinhar's view, a historian or writer of a preface should distinguish among the first publication of a literary form, its earliest experiments, discussions of its rules and its later expansion into book form. Using a subsequent book to obscure the earlier stages distorts the historical sequence.

2. Inconsistent Criteria for Determining the Beginning of a Genre

Anchinhar explains that the beginning of a literary form should be dated from its first verifiable publication, whether in a magazine or a book. His objection is that if the standard applied to one writer is "first book" and the standard applied to another is "first publication," literary historiography operates with a double standard. Anchinhar alleges that Raman Ji's preface does not sufficiently clarify this distinction.

3. Neglect of Earlier Publications and Experiments

Anchinhar refers to the essay "Maithili Haiku, Haiku and Kshanika" in Gajendra Thakur's book Kurukshetram Antarmanak, published in 2009, where Japanese literary forms such as tanka, senryū, haibun, haiga and waka are said to have been discussed. He also mentions instruction in these forms and the participation of numerous writers in Videha's Facebook group up to around 2012. In Anchinhar's view, Raman Ji's failure to acknowledge this earlier public history adequately in his preface is a significant omission.

4. Lack of Source References

Anchinhar alleges that Raman Ji explains the rules of tanka and other forms without citing earlier presentations of those rules in Maithili or identifying the available sources. In literary history or a critical preface, stating a fact alone is not enough: its source, earlier use and evidence must also be supplied. Anchinhar sees this absence of references as a weakness in scholarly writing.

5. Confusion in Assigning Credit

As Anchinhar reads it, the preface to Vyomak Ohipar leaves the impression that Dharmendra Vihwal introduced tanka, senryū, haibun, haiga, waka and related forms into Maithili. Anchinhar regards that impression as historically misleading because, according to him, these forms had already been discussed, their rules explained and experiments in writing them undertaken. A preface should therefore make the separate claims of credit explicit: "Who first introduced the form?", "Who produced the first single-genre collection?", and "Who popularised the form?"

6. Failure to Distinguish "First Book" from "First Appearance of the Genre"

Anchinhar presents a Facebook exchange reproduced in the appendix to his essay as support for his argument. The substance of that exchange is that Dharmendra Vihwal claims his book is the first book-length or single-genre work in this form; he does not claim that the form had never existed in Maithili before him. According to Anchinhar, Raman Ji's preface fails to establish this essential distinction clearly.

7. Allegations of Personal or Ideological Disagreement Affecting the Account

Anchinhar's criticism is not confined to errors of fact. He alleges that Gajendra Thakur's name and contribution were overlooked because of ideological disagreement or "tāmas" (hostile passion). This is a serious allegation. For Anchinhar, a historian's duty is to rise above personal likes and dislikes and assign credit impartially.

8. Failure to Engage with Contrary Evidence

Anchinhar issues a challenge: if tanka, senryū, haibun, haiga, waka and related forms existed in Maithili before Gajendra Thakur, and if their rules had already been discussed, the evidence should be produced. In other words, silence or the omission of a name is not enough; literary history requires documentary evidence for alternative claims. According to Anchinhar, Raman Ji's preface lacks an assessment of evidence at this level.

9. Failure to Fulfil the Preface Writer's Duty to Verify Sources

A book's preface is not merely an encomium, particularly when it makes claims about the history and rules of a literary form. In Anchinhar's view, Raman Ji should have drawn conclusions only after carefully examining earlier publications, chronology, lists of authors, public posts, books and all available evidence. The absence of such source verification weakens the preface as a critical document.

10. The Need to Correct the Historical Record

Anchinhar finally suggests a course of correction: if earlier facts are wrong, present fresh evidence; if there were earlier contributions, restore their names and proper credit. In his view, therefore, the fundamental failing of Raman Ji's writing in this instance is not simply a "mistake," but a remediable imbalance in the historical record.

Conclusion: The focus of Ashish Anchinhar's criticism is not Ramanand Jha 'Raman's language, style or total literary achievement. It is the particular preface's sense of history, sources, chronology, assignment of credit and impartiality. The substance of his allegation is that the earlier history of Japanese poetic forms in Maithili was not given its proper place, and the distinction between the "first book" and the "first appearance of a genre" was blurred. For these reasons, he regards the text as incomplete and affected by partiality from the standpoint of literary historiography.

Conclusion

When all these limitations are gathered together, a common thread becomes clear. Raman Ji's work is extensive in quantity, invaluable as an archive and inspired by love of his mother tongue—none of the contributors to this special issue calls that into question. Yet when that work is subjected to stringent tests of theoretical discipline, authenticity of sources, complete impartiality and institutional results, there remains considerable room for improvement: the risk of criticism without access to texts; unstable evaluative standards; excessive praise born of personal closeness; the limited presence of marginalised voices; institutional silence; and selective impartiality. These are invitations to further research, not punishments. The reviewer of Hiaol writes something equally applicable to the special issue as a whole: "Its excellence lies where the author searches the archives, corrects received errors and brings forgotten writers into view … Its limitation lies where conjecture takes the place of evidence and biography outweighs analysis of the work." To put it in Raman Ji's own words, "Vāde vāde jāyate tattvabodhaḥ"—understanding of truth arises through debate and counterargument. That understanding, born of disagreement and response, is the genuine achievement of this special issue.

Ramanand Jha 'Raman': An Editorial Perspective on the Boundaries of His Work

The place that Raman Ji occupies in Maithili literature emerges as beyond dispute from these seventeen contributions. But the special issue will fulfil its purpose only if, along with its praise, it identifies the limitations that the contributors themselves—and Raman Ji's own critical method—bring to light.

1. The Most Fundamental Limitation of His Critical Method: Criticism Without the Text

The extensive review of Akhiyasal (Contribution 4) makes it perfectly clear that Raman Ji frequently does not have access to the original texts of the works he critiques. In the cases of Chandraprabha, Trilochan Jha, Yaduvar and the forgotten Janardan Jha, he himself acknowledges their "unavailability." If the original work was not available to the critic, the question of how he could have undertaken its aesthetic evaluation remains unanswered. In many places the criticism depends on Jayakant Mishra's literary history or other secondary sources.

2. The Instability of Evaluative Standards

The reviews of these two books (Contributions 4 and 16) repeatedly demonstrate that Raman Ji treats one quality as paramount in one essay and praises its opposite in another. For example, his engagement with contemporary reality is considered a virtue in discussions of Ganganand Singh and Chandragrahan, yet Vyas's stories are praised precisely because they remain unaffected by contemporary reality. Such self-contradiction shows the absence of a single, declared theoretical commitment: the criticism becomes impressionistic in one place, sociological in another and biographical elsewhere.

3. Personal Closeness and the Lack of Critical Distance

In chapters on Lakshmipati Singh, Mohan and Rajeshwar Jha, personal affection turns criticism into a memoir-like tribute, affecting objectivity. By contrast, the critical courage displayed in the discussion of Harimohan Jha is not exercised with equal consistency throughout the collection.

4. The Absence of Theoretical Terminology

Elements of Indian poetics such as rasa, dhvani and vyañjanā are implicitly present, but there is no systematic theoretical application of Anandavardhana, Kuntaka, Kshemendra and others. Nor is there a considered application of Western theory. This makes the criticism readable, but deprives it of academic depth.

5. Narrowness of Perspective: The Limited Presence of Women and Marginalised Voices

Of the twenty-five essays in Akhiyasal, twenty-four concern male authors and only one a woman, Harilata—and even that discussion is restricted to Vaishnava devotion. Dalit and most-backward communities in Mithila, and the unnamed creators of oral tradition, are largely missing from this parallel history. Kumar Rahul's essay (Contribution 6) also observes that Raman Ji does not seem to follow fixed theoretical rules, but delivers judgements under the influence of a single element. In places he disposes of a writer or a work in a few words, as though writing a brief annotation, and devotes more space to his own observations.

6. Inconsistency in the Compilation

All twenty-five essays were written independently at different times and for different magazines. Assembling them as a "book" does not produce a uniform theoretical framework. The absence of an introduction, a statement of method and a conclusion exposes this composite character. The same applies to Hiaol, where the scope, method and depth of individual chapters are uneven.

7. The Gap Between Individual Dedication and Institutional Results

Praveen Kumar Jha's essay (Contribution 15) is the most outspoken voice in the special issue. With his "But, but, but!" he writes plainly that, despite Raman Ji's years in important positions in institutions such as Chetna Samiti and the Maithili Writers' Association, no decisive or concrete results of his work are clearly apparent in the campaign for Maithili's inclusion in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution or in Maithili education. The question is not his dedication but its results. The essay also mentions allegations and controversies associated with his tenure at Chetna Samiti and criticisms of a preference for diplomatic relations with those in power. Dr Dhanakar Thakur's predominantly satirical essay (Contribution 11) sharpens the same point, comparing Raman Ji and Chetna Samiti's silence on the question of a Mithila state to Dronacharya's "keeping his eyes closed."

8. The Question of Impartiality

The observation by Rajlin Thakur quoted in Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra's essay (Contribution 12) is explicit: "Raman Ji is both a person dear to him and a good critic, but he has one failing: he brings the work of a limited section of society to the fore more than the work of others, and at that point he cannot remain impartial." Nabonarayan Mishra's essay (Contribution 13) likewise points to the absence of an activist playwright such as Babusaheb Chaudhary from the register of literary figures.

9. Unevenness in Editorial Work

Pradeep Bihari's essay (Contribution 14) states explicitly that editing the magazine Ghar-Bahar does not exhibit the same skill found in Raman Ji's analytical and research-based books: the intellectual urgency needed for introductions and editorials is not equally visible everywhere. Kirtinath Jha's review of Vivarta (Contribution 10) also records a disagreement—"It is difficult to say whether this view is universally accepted"—when Raman Ji describes Maithili periodicals as "fully sensitive and responsible" towards the freedom movement.

10. Disagreement Among Readers

Ajit Kumar Jha's essay (Contribution 5) explicitly disagrees with Raman Ji's rereading of Kanyadan: the critic's argument appears one-sided, and the three groups into which Raman Ji divides Harimohan Jha's readers omit a fourth, comprising those who view Raman Ji's own literature as an attack on Mithila's culture.

Synthesis—All these limitations are joined by a common thread: Raman Ji's work is extensive in volume, invaluable in archival terms and inspired by love of his mother tongue. Yet in theoretical discipline, authenticity of sources, complete impartiality and institutional results, it leaves room for further progress. To express it in his own words, "Vāde vāde jāyate tattvabodhaḥ": understanding of truth arises through debate and counterargument.

109. The Late Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Premshankar Singh, and the Late Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' (1911–1998)

Abstract

Born on 18 September 1908 in Kumar Bajitpur, a village and post office in Vaishali district, Bihar, India. His father, the late Pandit Janardan Jha 'Jansidan', was a distinguished poet and man of letters of the Dwivedi era, writing in Hindi as well as Maithili. Education: MA in Philosophy, 1932; awarded a gold medal for securing the highest position in Bihar and Orissa.

Keywords: Harimohan Jha; Jagdish Prasad Mandal; Premshankar Singh; Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri'; Maithili literature; comparative rereading

The Late Harimohan Jha (1908–1984)

He was born on 18 September 1908 in Kumar Bajitpur, a village and post office in Vaishali district, Bihar, India. His father, the late Pandit Janardan Jha 'Jansidan', was a distinguished Hindi poet and man of letters of the Dwivedi era, besides being a Maithili writer. Harimohan Jha received his MA in Philosophy in 1932, winning a gold medal for taking first place in Bihar and Orissa. From 1933 he was a lecturer at B. N. College, Patna; from 1948 he taught at Patna College; from 1953 he was Professor and Head of Department at Patna University; and from 1970 to 1975 he served as a UGC Research Professor. His Maithili publications include the novels Kanyadan (1933) and Dwiragaman (1943); the short-story collections Pranamya Devata (1945), Rangshala (1949), and Charchari (1960); and the satire Khattar Kaka-k Tarang (1948). The second edition of the story collection Ekadashi appeared in 1987: it replaced 'Graduate Putohu' with 'Dwadash Nidan', a story previously published in Mithila Mihir but absent from the earlier collections. 'Baba-k Sanskar', written at the request of Ramanath Jha, is also included in that collection. Khattar Kaka appeared in Hindi book form in 1971. In addition, his scattered published poems were collected as Harimohan Jha Rachanavali, Volume 4 (Poetry), in 1999, and his autobiography, Jivan-Yatra, was published in 1984. Harimohan Babu's Jivan-Yatra was the only one of his books published by the Maithili Academy; for this work he received the Sahitya Akademi Award posthumously in 1985. In 1999 the Sahitya Akademi published a selection of his stories entitled Bichhal Katha, edited by Rajmohan Jha and Subhash Chandra Yadav. Some stories in that selection had appeared in none of his earlier collections. Many of his works have been translated into Hindi, Gujarati, Marathi, Kannada, Telugu, and other languages. His books in

Hindi include Nyaya Darshan, Vaisheshik Darshan, Tarkashastra (Deduction), a Hindi translation from English of Datta and Chatterjee's Indian Philosophy, and the edited collection Darshanik Vivechanayen. His English research monograph is Trends of Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy.

In the ancient period Vidyapati raised Maithili poetry to a lofty summit of achievement; Harimohan Jha brought modern Maithili prose to a comparable height. A defining feature of his writing was its witty and satirical assault on social and religious conventions, superstition, and hypocrisy. Even today his works are among the most widely purchased and read books in Maithili.

The Complete Works of Harimohan Jha

Let us take a panoramic look at the entirety of Harimohan Jha's writings.

Stories and One-Act Plays

1.1. Ayachi Mishra (one-act play); 2. Mandan Mishra (one-act play); 3. Maharaj Vijay (one-act play); 4. Baua-k Daam (The Boy's Price; one-act play); 5. Rail-k Jhagra (A Quarrel on the Train; one-act play); 6. Sangathan-k Samasya (The Problem of Organisation; epistolary form); 7. 'Rasmayi'-k Grahak (A Subscriber to 'Rasmayi'; epistolary form); 8. Panch Patra (Five Letters; epistolary form); 9. Dalan-par-k Gapp (Conversations on the Veranda); 10. Ghur-par-k Gapp (Conversations around the Fire); 11. Pokhari-par-k Gapp (Conversations by the Pond); 12. Chaupari-par-k Gapp (Conversations at the Meeting Place); 13. Dharmashastracharya (The Authority on Religious Law); 14. Jyotishacharya (The Astrologer); 15. Panditji.

16. Kaviji (The Poet); 17. Parivartan (Change); 18. Yug-k Dharma (The Duty of the Age); 19. Maharani-k Rahasya (The Queen's Secret); 20. Sat Rang-k Devi (The Goddess of Seven Colours); 21. Nau Lakh-k Gapp (A Tale of Nine Lakhs); 22. Rangshala (The Theatre); 23. Anchar-k Patil (The Pickle Jar); 24. Chikitsa-k Chakra (The Cycle of Treatment); 25. Reshmi Dolai (The Silk Quilt); 26. Dhokha (Deception); 27. Press-k Lila (The Ways of the Press); 28. Deviji-k Sanskar (Deviji's Rites); 29. Ehi Bate Abai Chhathi Sursari Dhar (The Ganges Flows This Way); 30. Kanya-k Jivan (A Girl's Life); 31. Rail-k Anubhav (An Experience on the Train); 32. Gramsevika (The Village Social Worker); 33. Maryada-k Bhang (Violation of Propriety); 34. Tirhutam; 35. Totma (A Charm); 36. Tirthayatra (Pilgrimage); 37. Alankar-Shiksha (Instruction in Figures of Speech); 38. Baba-k Sanskar (Father's Rites); 39. Dwadash Nidan (Twelve Diagnoses); 40. Graduate Putohu (The Graduate Daughter-in-Law); 41. Brahma-k Shap (Brahma's Curse); 42. Adarsh Bhojan (An Ideal Meal); 43. Sasur-k Chinh (A Sign of

the In-Laws' Home); 44. Kalibari-k Chor (The Thief at Kalibari); 45. Kalazar-k Upachar (Treatment of Kala-Azar); 46. Vinimay (Exchange); 47. Darogaji-k Monchh (The Inspector's Moustache); 48. Shastrartha (Scholarly Debate); 49. Vikat Pahun (The Formidable Guest); 50. Adarsh Kutumb (The Ideal Family); 51. Sajhi Ashram (The Communal Ashram); 52. Gharjamai (The Resident Son-in-Law); 53. Bhadesh-k Namuna (A Specimen of Vulgarity); 54. Bima-k Agent (The Insurance Agent); 55. Angrejiya Babu (The Anglicised Gentleman).

Verse

1. Sanatani Baba o Kaliyugi Sudharak (The Orthodox Elder and the Reformer of the Kali Age); 2. Kanya-k Nilami Dak (The Auction of a Daughter); 3. Mithila-k Mihir San (To Mithila Mihir); 4. Dhala Jha.

5. Tea Party; 6. Buchkun Jha; 7. Pandit Lokani San (To the Learned Gentlemen); 8. Nirasan Mama (Uncle Nirasan); 9. Agi (Fire); 10. Angrejiya Larki-k Samdauni (The English-Style Girl's Farewell Song).

11. Garibni-k Barahmasa (A Poor Woman's Twelve-Month Lament); 12. Shri Yatriji-k Prati: Maithili-k Ukti (To Shri Yatri: Maithili Speaks); 13. Saurath; 14. Alagi (Separation); 15. Ashok-Vatika-me (In Ashoka Grove).

16. Patna-Stotra (Hymn to Patna); 17. Shraddheya Amarnath Jha-k Prati Shraddhanjali (A Tribute to the Revered Amarnath Jha).

18. Hindi o Maithili (Hindi and Maithili); 19. Buchkun Babu-k Chitthi (Buchkun Babu's Letter).

20. Jagmag-Jagmag Dip Jarau (Light the Gleaming Lamps); 21. Kalkatta Gela Uttar (After Going to Calcutta).

22. Akal (Famine); 23. Kalkatta Hamra Bar Pasand (I Like Calcutta Very Much); 24. Salgam-k Khand (A Piece of Turnip); 25. Burhanath; 26. Navaki Pirhi San (To the New Generation); 27. Pandit o Mem (The Pandit and the Memsahib).

28. Pandit-Vilap (A Pandit's Lament); 29. Ganga-k Ghat-par (On the Banks of the Ganges); 30. Samay-k Chakra (The Wheel of Time).

31. Mahangi-Mahatmya (The Glory of High Prices); 32. Ras-Nimantran (An Invitation to Delight); 33. Akavita-k Prati: Kavita-k Ukti (Poetry Speaks to Anti-Poetry); 34. Ham Pahun Chhi (I Am a Guest); 35. Anagat Preyasi San (To a Beloved Yet to Come).

36. Matsya-Tirtha (The Fish Pilgrimage); 37. Mishtanna (Sweetmeats); 38. He Rajkamal (O Rajkamal); 39. Ghatak San (To the Matchmaker); 40. Panditji San (To Panditji); 41. Kaniya-k Samasya (The Bride's Problem); 42. Muktak (Independent Verses).

43. Ghazal; 44. Matribhoomi (Motherland); 45. Nari-Vandana (Salutation to Womanhood); 46. He Dulahi Ke May (O Mother of the Bride); 47. Matribhoomi-Vandana (Salutation to the Motherland); 48. Chandrama-k Mrityu (The Death of the Moon); 49. Mithila-Vandana (Salutation to Mithila); 50. Kavi He! Ab Kodari Dharu (O Poet, Take Up the Spade Now!); 51. Mahangi (Inflation); 52. Nav Parati (A New Dawn Song); 53. Chalis a Chauhattar (Forty and Seventy-Four).

54. Prayogvadi Kavita (Experimentalist Poetry); 55. Swargiya Lalit Narayan Mishra-k Smriti-me (In Memory of the Late Lalit Narayan Mishra); 56. Udgar (An Outpouring); 57. Antim Satya (The Ultimate Truth); 58. Madhur Bhasha Maithili Chhi (Maithili Is a Sweet Language); 59. Chhagunta; 60. Vidyapati Parva Mahan Hamar (Our Great Vidyapati Festival).

61. Ath Sankalp (Eight Resolutions); 62. Ghutar Kaka; 63. Vanagam-Mahishi Smriti (Memories of Vanagam-Mahishi).

64. Maithili-Vandana (Salutation to Maithili); 65. He Matribhoomi Ker Mati (O Soil of the Motherland).

66. Kahu Ki Au Babu (What Shall I Say, Sir?); 67. Kashmir Hamar Thik (Kashmir Is Ours); 68. Mangal Prabhat (An Auspicious Morning); 69. Buchkun Babu-k Swapna (Buchkun Babu's Dream); 70. Jai Vidyapati (Hail Vidyapati).

71. Shubhanshasa (Good Wishes); 72. Paricharika-Stotra (Hymn to the Attendant); 73. Manchan Baba.

74. Ehi Ber-k Phagua (This Year's Holi); 75. Parataru Juni (Do Not Deceive); 76. He Majur! Kasht Lakhi Ahank (O Labourer! Seeing Your Suffering; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata); 77. He He Majur! (O Labourer!; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata); 78. Abi! Anant Komal Karune! (Come, O Boundlessly Gentle Compassion!; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata); 79. He Vir! Halayudh Dhar Khadga (O Hero! Take Up the Plough-Weapon and the Sword; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata); 80. Ayi! Prachand Chandike! (O Fierce Chandika!; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata); 81. Jhansi-k Rani (The Queen of Jhansi; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata).

82. He Pragatisheel Mahila Samaj (O Progressive Women's Society; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata).

83. Priye! Ham Jait Chhi Ohi Par (Beloved, I Am Going to the Other Shore; from 'Kaviji', Pranamya Devata).

84. Dhanya-Dhanya Matribhoomi (Blessed, Blessed Motherland; from 'Ayachi Mishra', Charchari).

85. Dhanya I Mithilesh-k Darbar (Blessed Is This Court of Mithilesh; from 'Ayachi Mishra', Charchari).

86. He Dih! Amar Kirti-k Nidhan! (O Ancient Mound, Repository of Immortal Glory!; from 'Ayachi Mishra', Charchari).

87. Harihar Janma Kiek Lel (Why Was Harihar Born?; from 'The Importance of Fish', Khattar Kaka-k Tarang).

88. Kehan Bhel Anher (What Darkness Has Descended!; from 'Khattar Kaka's Latest Talk', Khattar Kaka-k Tarang).

Khattar Kaka-k Tarang (Narrative Satire)

Kanyadan (Novel)

Dwiragaman (Novel)

Jivan-Yatra (Autobiography)

The dedication of Kanyadan: 'To the leading men of that society which feels no compunction in giving away a girl as though she were an inanimate object; whose arbiters pour away thousands upon thousands of rupees on the education of boys but do not deem it necessary to buy even a slate worth a few small coins for a girl; in which the wife of a BA graduate does not even know the letters A and B; and which feels no pity in harnessing an innocent heifer beside a circus horse to pull the carriage of married life—to the thunderbolt-strong hands of that society's champions this book is dedicated humbly, earnestly, and with trepidation.'

The dedication of Pranamya Devata: 'To the man who, seven years ago, borrowed money from me on a promise concerning Kartik Purnima and has never since condescended to show himself again; whose unforgettable exploits are described at length in the very first story; who might claim the highest seat among the "deities worthy of reverence"; whose estimable relatives might establish their own claim to the book merely on seeing it, without even asking—to that principal hero of extraordinary character, the formidable guest Bhimendranath, I am compelled to present this book of extraordinary characters into his enormous, powerful fist!'

The dedication of Khattar Kaka-k Tarang: 'To the man who, riding the waves of bhang, sets flowing a current of poetry, learning, and wit, in which the Vedas, Puranas, and law-books are all washed away for a while; who mixes a syrup of extraordinary delight and wonder into every remark; whose piercing satire reaches the innermost heart and tickles it—to that eternal embodiment of joy, the laughter-loving Khattar Kaka: "What belongs to you, Uncle, I dedicate to you alone."'

> The dedication of Rangshala: 'To the ever-youthful actress who presides over this beginningless and endless theatre; the beautiful veena-player who sets the entire moving and unmoving universe dancing on the tips of her fingers; the mysterious enchantress who shows a glimpse of her captivating play but allows no one to touch her; the one who, arriving on the coloured wings of imagination, infuses the artist's art with aesthetic relish—to that wondrous, eternally beautiful, conqueror of the three worlds, the goddess Maya.'

Jagdish Prasad Mandal

Writing about the Bengal famine of 1942–43, Amartya Sen notes that hundreds of thousands died in Bengal—the Famine Inquiry Commission put the toll at 1.5 million—yet not one of his own relatives died in it. Likewise, during the famine in Mithila in 1967, India's Prime Minister was shown how members of the Musahar community were fighting starvation by eating bisandh. Yet a story on that subject did not appear until 2009. In 2009 Jagdish Prasad Mandal wrote a Maithili story about bisandh. The reason for the delay is clear as well: because of the one-sided tendency that had prevailed in Maithili literature, our writers, like Amartya Sen in this comparison, may not have been affected to the same degree by that enormous catastrophe. Jagdish Prasad Mandal's story saves the course of Maithili fiction from remaining one-sided. Every story in this collection is outstanding. Together they fill a gap and furnish evidence of a renaissance in Maithili literature.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal is an accomplished craftsman. He brings his material together so deftly that the reader is left astonished. But his insistence on making that material purposeful—and his ability to do so, whether in short stories, novels, plays, or inspirational stories—establishes him at a place in Maithili literature from which its history will be read in two parts: 'before Jagdish Prasad Mandal' and 'from Jagdish Prasad Mandal onward'. Every social group is present in his writing, not as an ornamental inclusion but naturally and without contrivance; for Maithili literature this is like the arrival of a great wave. Nowhere in his work does one encounter mere declamation about deprivation. The respect and dignity with which he presents the ways of life of every class are remarkable. Against employment-seeking and migration, his writing upholds the dignity of traditional livelihoods. Its force comes from his equal commitment to what he writes and what he actually does, and from the excellence of his personal and social life: he writes what he thinks and what he practises. Despite novelists such as Yatri and Dhumketu, and short-story craftsmen such as Kumar Pawan and Dhumketu, the Maithili language remained distant from ordinary people. The cadences and inflections of Maithili have always attracted people beyond Mithila as well.

Mandal's engaged literature, which reveals society, culture, and language through those same cadences and inflections, will bring change not only in Mithila's social sphere but also in its economic life. Five of his novels, one play, more than two dozen stories, and over a hundred inspirational stories for children and adolescents have been published electronically in Videha. They have stirred Maithili speakers scattered across the world and filled a vacant space in Maithili literature.

Premshankar Singh

The Late Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' (1911–1998)

The late Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' was born in 1911 at Satlakha, his maternal grandparents' village, situated near his ancestral village of Tarauni. Yatri began studying at the Sanskrit school in his village. He later went to Varanasi and Calcutta and earned the title of Sahityacharya in Sanskrit. After that he travelled to Kelaniya, near Colombo, to study Pali and Buddhism. There he was initiated into Buddhism and took the name Nagarjun. Later, however, he underwent the sacred-thread ceremony again in his village and returned to Brahmanical religious practice.

Yatri was influenced by Marxism. In the closing months of 1929 he began writing verse in Maithili, and from 1935 he wrote in Hindi as well. Alongside Swami Sahajanand Saraswati and Rahul Sankrityayan, he took part in the peasant movement and, in that connection, was imprisoned on several occasions between 1939 and 1941. Many of the works he wrote after Mahatma Gandhi's death were banned. Following the Communist Party's support for China during the Sino-Indian War, he developed differences with the party. He participated in the J. P. movement and was thrown into prison during the Emergency. Yatri also wrote children's literature in Hindi. Besides Hindi and Maithili, his writings appeared in Bengali and Sanskrit. He received the second Sahitya Akademi Award given for Maithili in 1969, for his poetry collection Patrahin Nagna Gachh (The Leafless Naked Tree). In 1994 he was elected a Fellow of the Sahitya Akademi in recognition of his standing as a poet in Hindi and Maithili.

When Yatri was twenty, he was married to a girl of twelve. His father, Gokul Mishra, was regarded as uneducated by his community and was a man of dissolute character. One of Yatri's childhood memories was of his father taking up an axe to attack his ailing, bedridden mother when the helpless woman begged him to abandon his wayward conduct. Yatri was only six when his mother died. Another image of his father haunted him repeatedly: his widowed aunt, who had loved him like a mother, nearly died while aborting a pregnancy resulting from his father's illicit relationship with her. Who among the readers of Yatri's Hindi novel

Ratinath ki Chachi has not wept again and again while reading it? The fierce conflict between father and son grew so intense that the son left his child-wife with his father and departed for Varanasi.

Let my aged father reap the fruits of his deeds;
I am his only offspring—that is his sin.
Knowing this, let him feel no anguish of mind.
Let even others forget my name.
Mother Mithila, this is my final farewell! (Kashi, November 1936)

From Kashi he went to Sri Lanka. With the words 'Let my aged father reap the fruits of his deeds', Yatri gave voice to all the feelings he harboured towards his father. In 1941 he returned to his wife, Aparajita. That year he wrote two Maithili poems, 'Burh Var' (The Old Bridegroom) and 'Vilap' (Lament), had them printed as pamphlets, and sold them to railway passengers. Husband and wife travelled all over India in search of a livelihood. At his wife's insistence he would occasionally return to Tarauni. Then came 1949, bringing with it Yatri's first collection of Maithili poetry, Chitra. Until 1952 his wife accompanied him in his travels, after which she began living in Tarauni; Yatri visited from time to time. He and Aparajita had six children, and she carried the responsibility for all of them on her own shoulders. Yatri suffered from asthma.

When I was studying in Darbhanga, Yatri lived in Khwaja Sarai. I remember that he once attended a Maithili event at which Communist Party members had taken over the agenda. The following day he withdrew from the proceedings of the meeting that had descended into such confusion. During the Emergency, when he was imprisoned, he met RSS workers in jail. After his release he also wrote against J. P.'s Total Revolution. He published in Maithili under the name Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' and in Hindi under the name 'Nagarjun'.

'Prithvi Te Patram' was published in Vaidehi in 1954 and was part of our matriculation syllabus. Yatri writes:

> 'Other festivals may be one thing or another, but Nawan lays bare the condition of the landless family. So, as soon as Kartik arrives, Aparajita Devi's veil hangs low. Her eyes are so pained that she cannot even lift her lids towards anyone! Where has anyone ever celebrated Nawan with grain purchased from the market?'

Is Yatri a myth? Yes, is Yatri a myth? He was principally a writer in Hindi: he did not produce in Maithili even a tenth of what he wrote in Hindi, and a large proportion of what he did produce in Maithili consisted of his own translations from Hindi. The vocabulary and culture of Maithili and the Mithila region seemed unfamiliar, and therefore fascinating, to Hindi readers. Yet there were many shortcomings even here. Take this example

from Yatri Samagra: on page 220, 'The death anniversary of his paternal uncle fell on Jeth Sudi Chaturdashi'; then on page 222, '...where could he go even for a single day to officiate as karta, on the first date of Asarh Badh Tritiya?'

Other writers working in both Maithili and Hindi suffer from the same malady. It is a documented historical fact that Gonu Jha lived between 1050 and 1150, yet Usha Kiran Khan has him engage in a scholarly disputation with Vidyapati (in her Hindi historical novel Sirjanhara, published by Bharatiya Jnanpith). Virendra Jha says Gonu Jha lived five hundred years ago; Taranand Viyogi places him three hundred years ago (in their respective Hindi books on Gonu Jha, published by Rajkamal Prakashan and the National Book Trust); and in Vibha Rani's Hindi book on Gonu Jha (Vani Prakashan), Kunal places him under the rule of Bhav Singh in the fourteenth century. Such is the state of affairs even though written records in the panji genealogies place Gonu Jha ten generations before Vidyapati. Vocabulary and culture particular to Mithila seem obscure, and therefore intriguing, to Hindi readers; but through their ignorance these Maithili–Hindi writers are serving up numerous erroneous 'facts'. Sectarian writers are even inserting the oppression of Muslim revenue officials into Gonu Jha stories—although, Muslims were not living in Mithila in Gonu's time at all!

Chaturanan Mishra and Jagdish Prasad Mandal have both been associated with the Communist movement in practical work at the party level. Yet after reading the novels of these two writers, I have no hesitation in saying that they do not feel any need for the crutch of Marxism on which Yatri and Dhumketu prop up their novels. The true meaning of Marxism is to be found in the works of these two writers. Nowhere is there a discussion of a party's name or an ideology; instead, one finds a recognition of genuine dialectical materialism, a belief in the importance of life, and the application of a dialectical method. This becomes possible only when a writer studies Marxism deeply, including Das Kapital, and remains engaged in practical Marxism for decades.

And, finally, these Sanskrit verses by Yatri:

> *The golden radiance of spring is doubled,*
> *by leaves of yellow and ruddy red;*
> *with the play of golden lotuses in mind,*
> *the bees remain at a distance;*
> *these trees make the tales of pleasure groves*
> *forgotten here upon the earth;*
> *their shimmering shade sways and changes,*
> *these are the chinar trees.*

The golden glow of spring is doubled by yellow and red new leaves. The bees, under the illusion that this is a golden age, keep far away. Their beauty causes one to forget the pleasures of the celestial Nandana grove upon the earth. Their shadows flicker, growing and diminishing; their movement is restless and fluid. I have seen those chinar trees standing firm and unmoving.

110. A Review of the Complete Literary Works of Subhash Chandra Yadav and the Kamalanand Jha Question in Maithili Criticism

Abstract

This extensive chapter offers a sequential review of the entire body of Subhash Chandra Yadav's Maithili writing. From *Ghardekhiya* to *Gulo*, it examines his stories and novels, language, folk life, social structures and creative development. It also incorporates a critical discussion of trends in Maithili literary criticism and the questions surrounding Kamalanand Jha.

Keywords: Subhash Chandra Yadav; Ghardekhiya; Gulo; short story; novel; folk life; language; Maithili criticism

The Ever-New Subhash Chandra Yadav

(Writer's Block—Writing in Maithili's Parallel Current: The Complete Literary Works of Subhash Chandra Yadav)

Subhash Chandra Yadav (1948–) was born on 5 March 1948 at his maternal family's home in Diwanganj, Supaul. His ancestral village is Balwa-Menahi, Supaul.

First phase of original writing in Maithili: *Ghardekhiya* (1983).

Second phase of original writing in Maithili: *Banait Bigarait* (serialised in the *Videha* e-journal from 2008 to 2009, then published as a book in 2009); *Gulo* (published in *Mithila Darshan* in 2014, then as a book in 2015); *Ramta Jogi* (2019); *Madar* (2021); the Rajkamal Chaudhary monograph (rejected by the Sahitya Akademi in January 1997, published in the December 2005–March 2006 issue of *Rachna*, and issued in book form in 2022 as *Nit Naval Rajkamal*); and *Bhot* (2022).

"Whoever tells the stories rules this world"—a proverb of the Hopi, a Native American people.

And Subhash Chandra Yadav stopped telling stories.

Swapnasundari and the Magical Birds of Mithila (Geeta Dharmarajan, story, 1996)

The singing birds were very fond of Swapnasundari, the little princess of Mithila. But she would turn fish, goats and cows into birds as well. The people reproached the princess; she took offence and stopped turning things into birds. She would not even come out of her palace. Then the birds that had survived in the magical land of Mithila disappeared too. The

women still sang in the fields, but without the many-coloured birds, Mithila no longer seemed like the Mithila it had once been. Then came the traders in trees. They persuaded people that trees were useless without birds, deceived them, cut down every tree in Mithila and carried the timber away. The women tried every device they could think of to save at least a few trees, but they could not. Without trees, all the streams dried up. Without trees, the people grew poorer and poorer, while the traders grew richer and richer. The women went weeping to the princess: "Princess, help us. We were wrong." Swapnasundari sat in her room, where pictures of many-coloured birds covered the walls on every side. Looking at those pictures, the princess of Mithila spoke sadly: "No, you were right. Birds alone cannot keep us happy." But the women answered, "Nor can we be happy without the birds. Bring them back, Princess." The princess was so miserable that she could no longer work her magic. Then the women said, "Never mind. We shall plant trees, and the singing birds will return. And this time we shall not allow anyone to cheat us." All Mithila began to labour as though possessed. No one had a moment's leisure. Singing and dancing, they planted and watered the trees. As the trees grew taller and spread wider, everyone began to laugh and clap. Working together brought them joy. Perhaps that was why the trees themselves grew better and faster. Large and small trees seemed to smile on every side in Swapnasundari's country of Mithila. Magical music spread in every direction. These would become homes for birds of seven colours: red, *jomak*, sky-blue, yellow, pink and the colour called *panisokha*. The princess said to the women, "I have always dreamed that the girls of our country would go to school." The women replied, "Yes, Princess. Had we been educated, no trader could have deceived us." But a difficulty arose. Some among the women asked, "Then who will do the work at home?"

The princess of Mithila then commanded that boys should learn the work that girls did, and girls should learn the work that boys did. Everyone would be happier if they moved forward together. Swapnasundari gave a bicycle to every girl who attended school. She explained that people throughout the world who can travel quickly from one place to another are happier, because they can finish all their work more swiftly. The women asked, "May we not ride bicycles too?" "Why not?" the princess replied. "Women should be able to do whatever work they like." Some asked the princess, "But where will the money come from?" The others silenced them. "Must the princess do everything herself?" They organised a great fair. Money was collected, and Princess Swapnasundari's school was built. The school works magic: children who enter it become like birds of many colours. "Why don't you come to the school yourself, Princess?" She came one day, and again the next, until she began coming every day. Then she said that the children's mothers and fathers should come to school too.

And the princess began to work magic again. This time, however, she turned only useless things into birds. And many birds with wings of every colour came back to Mithila of their own accord, without the use of magic. Each carried a thousand books in its beak—books that brought delight, red, pink and sky-blue books; the seven colours of red, *jomak*, yellow, pink and *panisokha*. Green, luxuriant trees had taken the place of sand. And the birds sang: "Beauty without knowledge is like a dried-up stream." The Mithila of that little princess became the greenest and most cheerful country in the world. People even say that the magic in Mithila's air is always there because of those birds. And what if we too should find such a place, a place where women and men could think great thoughts! Might that magical place be somewhere close to us? Might the place of magical things be inside ordinary people like ourselves? If you discover this place, wherever it may be, please let me know at my e-mail address: editorial.staff.videha@gmail.com.

Subhash Chandra Yadav stopped telling stories.

But from 1983 onward he stood his ground alone. Even some writers from what are today called the lower social strata went along with Maithili's artificial spelling conventions, leaving him isolated; they too became victims of gaslighting. Traders began to swarm on every side. Like the little princess, he continued to watch …

But from 1 January 2008, after eight years of preparation, *Videha*, the Maithili e-journal, began planting trees in Mithila, fortnight after fortnight; and the many-coloured birds began to return.

After breaking a silence of twenty-five years, Nachiketa began publishing *No Entry: Ma Pravish* in the fortnightly *Videha* e-journal. In that same year, after twenty-five years, Subhash Chandra Yadav began telling stories to *Videha*'s readers, fortnight after fortnight. Yadav's *Ghardekhiya* had appeared in 1983. Twenty-five years later, *Banait Bigarait* was published electronically in *Videha* in 2008–09 and then in print in 2009.

"Whoever tells the stories will rule this world"; and the parallel current is telling stories. Mithila's birds, their wings displaying many colours, have returned: Sandeep Kumar Safi, Umesh Paswan, Bechan Thakur, Kapileshwar Raut, Umesh Mandal, Ram Vilas Sahu, Rajdev Mandal, Nand Vilas Rai, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Durganand Mandal, Acharya Ramanand Mandal, Lalan Kumar Kamat, Narayan Yadav, Munni Kamat, Shiv Kumar Prasad, Dhirendra Kumar and Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jharudar" have arrived with stories and songs in a multitude of colours.

They have returned, each carrying a thousand books in its beak—books that bring joy, books of red, pink, *jomak*, *panisokha*, the seven colours and sky-blue. For rich green trees have taken the place of sand.

And Subhash Chandra Yadav began telling stories once more.

After *Banait Bigarait* came *Ramta Jogi*, *Gulo*, *Madar* and *Bhot*. The monograph on Rajkamal Chaudhary, rejected by the Sahitya Akademi, appeared under the title *Nit Naval Rajkamal*. And that is why Subhash Chandra Yadav is the "Ever-New Subhash Chandra Yadav."

Maithili Story Science (Maithila Narratology) and Subhash Chandra Yadav

Michel Foucault's "disciplinary institution" and what the psychologists Barton and Whitehead call "gaslighting" have the same objective. A disciplinary institution, in the Foucauldian sense invoked here, brings the person before it under discipline: set everyone against everyone else, reward some, and slowly administer poison to those who refuse to submit. In gaslighting, the person concerned is made to believe that their challenge to the status quo is no challenge at all: everyone is doing the same thing, they are told, and they are protesting merely for the sake of protesting, to conceal their own inadequacy. Existing fundamental deficiencies in society are also exploited for this purpose. Gradually the target either loses their mental equilibrium or withdraws.

Thus Subhash Chandra Yadav's writer's block was no ordinary writer's block; it was "gaslighting."

But Story Science provides a response. It analyses in advance what effect a particular story, once told, will have on people and society. The parallel current therefore decided to counter poison with poison. Those mainstream writers who twisted language in the name of standardisation were, through gaslighting, acting against Story Science. Their aim was to designate differences of spelling as errors. Writing with *Ghardekhiya* in view, Ramdev Jha argued that the principle "write as you speak," having failed in Assamese, would fail in Maithili too.

And Subhash Chandra Yadav was left alone.

But when Ramanand Jha "Raman" deployed this same Story Science alongside *biśāṛh*, and, in that context, Umesh Mandal sent me a story by Jagdish Prasad Mandal whose spelling Shivshankar Srinivas had corrected —having also pointed out, as though conferring a favour, that he had worked three days to remove its "errors"—I became immediately alert.

This was because stories using Subhash Chandra Yadav's own spellings had by then begun to appear electronically in *Videha*. I explained the import of Story Science to Umesh Mandal, and works in their original, supposedly uncorrected spelling began to be published in *Videha*. [See *Dudh-Pani Farak-Farak* (story and manuscript by Jagdish Prasad Mandal;

photography and editing by Umesh Mandal).] *Dudh-Pani Farak-Farak* (story and manuscript by Jagdish Prasad Mandal; photography and editing by Umesh Mandal).

Umesh Mandal informed me that after the spelling "corrections," Jagdish Prasad Mandal had become withdrawn. But from the day he learned that the conventionally "corrected" version of his work had been rejected by *Videha*, and that the version with his own authentic spelling would now be published electronically, he was filled with fresh enthusiasm.

Umesh Mandal then spoke with Subhash Chandra Yadav. Yadav told him, "Write whatever you like to the mainstream people. They will not listen; they will not even pay attention." He had also placed great trust in Rajmohan Jha, whom he addressed as an elder brother. "Then what is the remedy?" "The remedy is exactly what you are doing: increase the number of writers."

And Story Science says the same thing: those who tell stories will rule, and the more stories one tells, the further one will advance. Even Brihaspati, standing alone, would be judged false. But in this second phase Subhash Chandra Yadav was no longer alone.

For fifteen years the parallel current has been telling stories, while the mainstream has been listening.

Yet all the institutions described here as Michel Foucault's "disciplinary institutions"—the Sahitya Akademi, the Maithili Academy, the Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy, and the so-called literary associations recognised by the Sahitya Akademi—are in the mainstream's hands.

But Story Science has put an end to the techniques of mainstream gaslighting, including the disciplinary practices and the technique of offering to become someone's "guardian."

Story Science exposed Taranand Viyogi's vocabulary: (1) "Novels are pouring out in Maithili by the wholesale lot"; (2) "the language of sweepers"; and (3) "a conspiracy to erect mountains of rubbish"; as well as Ramanand Jha "Raman"'s phrase (1) "the language of the market and bazaar" (in his foreword to Dr Pramod Kumar's *Kankirba*).

These are all techniques of gaslighting suited to discouraging writers; the parallel current, with the help of Story Science, has overcome them. The examples also demonstrate that people of every caste are present in both the mainstream and the parallel current. Story Science has helped identify not only Brahminism but also a new Brahminism among non-Brahmins.

It was for the same reason, the argument continues, that an attempt was made to swallow up *Sagar Rati Dip Jaray*, the Maithili storytelling

gathering, under the auspices of the Sahitya Akademi. When that attempt failed, Ramanand Jha "Raman" and others in the mainstream could no longer preserve their composure. Raman went so far as to make unprintable remarks about Umesh Mandal and me, without naming us, in the journal of a Brahminist organisation; and, as a reward, the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi recognised that organisation as a so-called literary association. This episode illustrates the effect of Story Science.

Ashok, however, is delighted that writers of the parallel current have been organising *Sagar Rati Dip Jaray* for the past ten years. He says, "Its original purpose was to hold gatherings from village to village. Only now is that actually happening." Shivshankar Srinivas made the very same point at the eighty-second *Sagar Rati Dip Jaray*, held in my village [*The Buddhist Siddha Mehthapa*, a children's-literature-centred storytelling gathering, Menhath]: "When we began *Sagar Rati Dip Jaray*, our intention was to take it from village to village; instead it began travelling between Patna and Chennai." *The Buddhist Siddha Mehthapa* (children's literature centred), Menhath.

Meanwhile, Ram Bharos Kapri "Bhramar" and Parmeshwar Kapri had stood firm across the border in Nepal. Their writings were not included in the anthologies of Indian government institutions on the ground that they were outsiders, from Nepal. Yet works by other Nepali writers who sided with the status quo were included.

Julia Kristeva's axis of longitudinal relationships; Julia Kristeva's axis of vertical relationships / Jacques Derrida—poststructuralism, that is, deconstructive theory

The journey of storytelling runs through Vedic narratives, the Jataka tales, Aesop's fables, the *Panchatantra* and the *Hitopadesha*, while folk narratives have continued alongside them. Everywhere the stories of the elite have existed beside folk tales; this is true of Maithili too.

Subhash Chandra Yadav's views on this subject are as follows:

"Very little work has been done on folktales in Maithili. Only a handful of collections are available, and these have been written down from memory rather than on the basis of fieldwork. Whatever the unit of folk literature, more than one version of it exists; these variants can be recovered through fieldwork. Memory retains only one version, and it may be a mistake to treat that version as the best. Every collection of folktales compiled so far is incomplete. In Maithili, at least some fieldwork has been undertaken on folk songs, folk ballads and folk deities; almost no fieldwork appears to have been carried out on folktales. Now that the transmission of folk literature from one generation to the next is increasingly endangered,

preservation has become necessary. Folk literature must be preserved not merely because it belongs to the past. It is also a discourse and a form of self-narration belonging to its own time, and it offers a model. We continue, in our different ways, to use its metaphors, symbols, emotions and techniques in written literature. Conversely, written literature continually influences folk literature. Studies of folk literature have concentrated chiefly on establishing place and period. Questions concerning its function, intention and meaning remain neglected. In Maithili, the study of folk literature has not yet properly begun. The books that exist offer definitions and lists of folk literature. Among the available collections of folktales, a large proportion consists of stories that entered Maithili through migration. Relatively few are indigenous Maithili folktales—tales we could call authentically Maithil. Even the collection of Maithili folktales compiled by Ramlochan Thakur, on which I have based this very brief study, contains few authentically Maithili stories. To discuss the intentions and meanings of folktales, I have chosen two: 'There Once Was an Old Woman' and 'I Ate Just One Grain, Brother.' Both inhabit an entirely Maithil setting. Their discourse, self-narration and models accord with the Maithil imagination. Both centre their discussion on justice. In the first story an old woman challenges the carpenter, the king, the queen, fire, water and the elephant in order to obtain justice for a single grain of lentil, because a wooden peg has concealed her lentil and refuses to return it. The tale expresses its argument in verse:

Elephant, elephant, elephant!
Drink up the sea, O sea.
The sea will not put out the fire, the fire.
The fire will not frighten the queen, the queen.
The queen will not persuade the king, the king.
The king will not punish the carpenter, the carpenter.
The carpenter will not split the peg, the peg.
The peg will not give me my lentil, my lentil.
What shall I eat? What shall I drink?
What shall I take when I go to a foreign land?

She sets out. The peg gives way. Then, afraid of the peg, the elephant; afraid of the elephant, the sea; afraid of the sea, the fire; afraid of the fire, the queen; afraid of the queen, the king; and afraid of the king, the carpenter—all become willing to see justice done, and the peg returns the lentil to the old woman. Ramlochan had heard this story from his mother. He said that in his mother's version the old woman turned back after reaching the elephant. When writing it down, he recreated it. In his written version, the old woman goes beyond the elephant, all the way to the peg. Taking her as far as the peg expands the tale's suggestive

significance. But how far is this kind of documentation of a folktale justified? The tale's self-narration is expressed through the old woman. Her response to her situation is the tale's self-narration. With nothing but a grain of lentil, she prepares to leave for a foreign land. She rejects the king and queen's offer of a full *ser* of lentils. She refuses the sea's gift of diamonds and pearls. She keeps struggling for her right to her own lentil. The point is that one must have dreams. One must not make oneself an object of begging or pity. It is not good to accept alms. One must have self-respect and fight for one's rights. The model established by the story is that justice is obtained through struggle. 'I Ate Just One Grain, Brother' considers the exercise of judgment in the administration of justice. A *muniya* bird is to be sentenced to death for the offence of eating a single grain of *china* millet. The discussion proceeds in verse, which also depicts her pitiful condition:

> *Brother who owns the oxen!*
> *My nest, my little nest, is on the mountains and hills;*
> *My children are starving to death.*
> *I ate just one little grain, brother,*
> *And for that I am being taken captive.*

"Then the horse-owner comes, the elephant-owner comes, and the owner of broken grain comes. The *muniya* appeals to all of them. They too plead with the owner of the field, offering him an ox, a horse or an elephant in exchange for her release, but he refuses to budge. Only when the bird is on the verge of dying of hunger and thirst does he let her go in exchange for the broken grain. The *muniya* calls upon compassion and humanity. The *Manusmriti* says that quietly plucking someone's flower is not theft; likewise, eating a single grain of someone else's millet is no crime. This is the self-narration of the tale. The model it establishes is that every living being's life has equal value. Even the helpless and the poor have the right to live. There must be a space for them in this world."

The likelihood of failure is greater in the short story than in the novel, epic or extended narrative, because the novel is a "soap opera," continuing for months or years, with each episode reaching a particular point at its close. In a seventy-episode novel, that means hope remains through the sixty-ninth episode that the story may yet take a new turn; even if its direction never changes before the end, all the earlier episodes can be hits and only the last one a flop. The short story grants no such latitude. It is a work in a single episode: if good, thoroughly good; if not, thoroughly bad.

If we move beyond tales and ballads, the history of the modern short story begins towards the end of the nineteenth century. It came to be recognised in the forms of the very short story, the short story, and the tale, although the distinctions among these three were also elaborated unnecessarily. This

journey, beginning with Rabindranath Tagore, advanced from one end of India to the other as a consequence of reformist movements. Bezbarua in Assamese, Fakir Mohan Senapati in Odia, Apparao in Telugu, and Kedarnath Banerjee in Bengali spoke out at times in support of women and at times against society's moneylenders. In Nepali, Suryakanta Gyawali wrote "Devi ko Bali" against the practice of animal sacrifice at Dussehra. Some stories opposed the barriers of caste and wealth placed in the way of love; others concerned the condition of Dalit society and religious superstition. Nor did all these stories invariably end happily.

Movements, literature: postmodernism, existentialism, and humanism are all philosophical schools of thought. Earlier, philosophy encompassed science, history, society and politics, economics, the sciences of art, and language. But as branches of science and art, particularly science, acquired their own specialisations, mathematics and science within philosophy became restricted to mathematical logic. Philosophers turned towards the study of inductive and deductive methods and towards analytical method. Marx, who seemed like a divine intervention on behalf of the poor throughout the world, made dialectical method the foundation of his interpretation. The present-day "discussion" or dialectic, which includes both a position and its opposition, already existed in philosophy's method of refutation and establishment (*khaṇḍana–maṇḍana*; see Madhvacharya's *Sarvadarśanasaṅgraha*).

Thus Francis Fukuyama, who announced the end of history following the collapse of communist rule, later withdrew from that position. After communist governments fell and the Berlin Wall came down, Fukuyama declared that history, generated by the clash or dialectic of ideologies, had reached its end, and that henceforth only an ideology serving human welfare would advance. But some time later he dissociated himself from this view, saying that many divergent ideologies still survived within societies and among nationalities. Similarly, the postmodern thinker Jacques Derrida deconstructed language to show that its disassembled elements depend on numerous different foundations, and that we cannot determine language's meaning without understanding them.

Postmodernism, too, has stalled after its initial enthusiasm. Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, Romanticism, and sociological analysis have maintained their existence by becoming parts of a synthetic method of criticism.

Because psychoanalysis rests on a scientific basis, it will survive, like dialectical method.

What is the modern short story? What should it be like? Does it have, or should it have, any purpose? And how is that to be determined?

Psychology, too, provides the basis of a story. Its purpose should accord with the needs of society, and the changes in its narrative journey should correspond to changes that have occurred, and are occurring, in society. Yet the story is at the same time governed, of itself, by the culture of that society. Its historical existence comes to the fore within it.

If we speak of Vedic narratives, they bring love for the nation to the forefront and teach people to live together in society. Jātaka stories, together with the dissemination of popular languages, also sought to spread Buddhism.

In the Muslim world, a work such as Rumi's *Masnavi* is a distinguished text of Persian literature, teaching the importance of knowledge and the advancement of the state.

The story of today embraces all these things and moves towards the creation of an enlightened and humane society. If it does not do so, this should be included among its aims. Only then can the analysis and criticism of stories become a necessity for the reader.

As with psychoanalysis and dialectical method, the analyses of Fukuyama and Derrida, too, will be synthesised and will endure as lasting models for criticism.

For whom should we write, or tell, stories? A dispute concerning stories: those about whom we write will not themselves read them. Will people become enlightened by reading a story? There is no shortage of those who tell lies while swearing upon the *Gita*. Does that diminish the importance of stories written with such a standard in view?

Not everyone will become enlightened, but they can at least obtain wholesome entertainment. And if even one person reads a story and begins to think in that direction, the story will have proved its worth. Even if the people for whom it is written do not read it, those capable of intervening in their circumstances will. As long as that possibility remains, stories of this kind will continue to be written.

And if society changes, will social values remain eternal? Should the progressive story reconstruct experience for a changing society, enabling adjustment between natural and social reality? Or, to give this changing age stability, do we need stories founded upon the enduring and essential elements of tradition? The interests of the individual and those of society stand in a duality, in mutual opposition. They need to be brought into conjunction. A worldview is necessary. A story is not merely the product of an idea that we somehow transfer with ink onto paper. It is directed by social and historical circumstances.

Then should the story be idealistic, naturalistic, or realistic? Or should it be humanistic, socialist, or a sense-based realism that values experience? Alternatively, should it be purposive? This last encompasses utilitarianism, experimentalism, pragmatism, causalism, instrumentalism, and consequentialism. It is the most modern standpoint of all. Self-expression is human nature, but it becomes confined by social rules and influenced by circumstances.

A story, therefore, should be fashioned by reconstructing experience. Individual consciousness will then be able to become social and collective consciousness. The exploiter will have to curb his tendencies, while those exploited will have to oppose them openly.

Freedom—social transformation. Only then will the story be communicated and become a medium of dialogue. Only then can it become a weapon for society, a source of power.

If the storyteller preaches, he will merely transfer knowledge, which is no longer what is needed. Only when the storyteller begins a dialogue will an atmosphere of liberation emerge, and the readers participating in that dialogue will be released from inertia.

Only if a story is sequential and accessible can it achieve this objective. It will become practical rather than merely intellectual. The generosity of narratives in Vedic literature gave birth to dialogue, which the rigidity of Purāṇic literature brought to an end.

To restore dialogue, the storyteller must have faith—faith grounded in reason and faith grounded in experience—which Subhash Chandra Yadav possesses. The analytical philosophy of positivism analyses linguistic statements and concepts, not objects; this will be seen throughout Subhashji's stories. Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism arose as reactions to science. Through them, the ambiguities in scientific thinking were clarified.

Phenomenology studies the givens of consciousness precisely as they are given. Perception is the observation of the facts of particular mental acts. It is a means of seeing an object in an absolute and pure form. In existentialism, a human being is simply a human being. Apart from what one creates, one is nothing: one is condemned to be free (Sartre). Through Hegel's dialectics, emphasis was placed on determining the qualities of processes and judgments about existence by analysing and synthesising their endless inner relationships. The deeper an essential element lies, the further it will be from outward form and the nearer to reality.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also influenced modern thought. Beyond visible reality, internal and external processes

become possible through the exchange of minute elements of force and energy. Under the uncertainty principle, position and form must be determined by approximation.

The conception of a universe of more than three dimensions and Stephen Hawking's *A Brief History of Time* are directly undermining the existence of God, because the conception of God's death has also come to the fore; thus the existence of a controller of the universe is now imperilled. In the context of the death of God and the end of history, how long will the Maithili story go on simply telling tales? How long will it remain occupied with analyses of miniature, ultra-short (*bīhani*) stories, short stories, tales, and the like?

Just as virtual reality artificially presents reality and unites consciousness with it, so, without imagining more than three dimensions, even if we travelled from the Indus Valley civilisation at the speed of light, we could not yet have reached the other side of the universe. Our sun is one mediocre star among billions upon billions of other suns. We, inhabitants of a tiny village on the planet Earth orbiting that mediocre star, sit with our heads in our hands, worriedly asking: whose problems could be greater than ours? All these scientific and philosophical facts have appeared as challenges before our stories.

We will have to bring about a holistic synthesis, an integration of the whole! Only then will this philosophy pass from the merely philosophical into actuality.

Poststructuralist methodology locates the meaning of language not in words, their meanings, or grammatical rules, but in the process through which meaning is produced. For different persons and groups, language assumes different meanings. There is no final relationship between language and the world. Neither a word nor its text has an ultimate meaning, or a single meaning of its own.

On this matter Subhash Chandra Yadav has the following to say:

> "To expect a writer to explain and interpret his own work is an unreasonable expectation. That is not the writer's task. However difficult or controversial the work may be, the writer is responsible for it, but is not obliged to become its commentator. To how many people should a writer go about explaining his work, and why? Is such a thing possible? If the writer wishes, he can establish some dialogue concerning his work during his lifetime, but what happens after his death? Readers read a work according to their own understanding and judgment. Every age has its own distinct understanding. Thus this diversity and mutability of readings are necessary qualities of every powerful work. With the passage of time, the emotional purport of a

work keeps changing. So when an age changes, the interpretation of the work also changes. In this way a work does not have only one uniform reading; a valuable work admits infinitely many readings. A writer has no control over its readings. He should therefore have no need to offer a defence or explanation for their differences. My own experience is that unless an event is illuminated by an artistic vision, it cannot be transformed into a literary work. Different readers grasp that initial vision in different ways and interpret it differently. I feel that even if a reader cannot understand the vision and philosophy of a work, he certainly grasps its heart; he takes its emotional element to heart. An example from a folktale will make the point clearer. 'Brother, let me play one little grain, and they carry me away for that'—even if the reader cannot grasp the discourse and philosophy of justice and equality contained in these words, he certainly feels the little bird's cry of anguish for freedom. Similarly, even if it is not easy to understand the vision or philosophy of love as a life-giving force in my stories 'River' and 'Bride Doll', the reader nonetheless experiences affection. This feeling, this innermost emotional truth, is the essential thing in literature. Any idea or philosophy should reach the reader through feeling, not as dry disputation or slogan-shouting. As I understand it, love is the foundation of religion and culture. There is no feeling in this world greater than love. My stories do not proceed with any ideological or moralistic insistence. They express the conduct and ideas of their age, but are not bound by them. I believe a work of art does not bring about a revolution. It changes people's emotional disposition and outlook in a very subtle manner, becoming one constituent of long-term social change. Nothing beyond that. A critic who approaches literature with a different demand or insistence—as with Maithili's obstinate 'consciousness-oriented' position—will deceive himself and mislead others."

Modern and postmodern arguments, reality, dialogue, and the exchange of ideas gave rise to modernity. But then the New Left movement arose in France, as did such ideological movements as nihilism and anarchism. These modern processes of thought were grounded in a distrust that had emerged outside established faiths and concepts.

Interpretations began to examine meanings concealed within a text in the context of place and time, and language came to be treated as a medium of play—a "language game". Out of these developments emerged postmodernism as a critique of power, legitimacy, and their stratification.

Consider the computer and information revolution: a developer creates software and places it on the worldwide internet; the software thereafter goes on functioning independently of its maker, sometimes performing

tasks for which it was not designed. Other, intrusive software, such as viruses, diverts it from its course and makes it destructive. An antivirus is itself software that repairs the damage caused by such a virus; when even that cannot repair it, the computer is backed up and reformatted—a clean slate!

Capitalism arose from the Industrial Revolution, and now, in postindustrial society, information and communication have gained importance over production, while the computer has assumed an increasing role in society. Mobile phones, credit cards, and all such devices are based on chips. During the Kosi flood of 2008, Gaurinathji was stranded in his village, struggling even to obtain food, yet an air-conditioned railway ticket was booked for him using a credit card. What better example could one need of the role of information and computing in Mithila's society? In *Gulo*, too, we encounter the business of charging mobile phones.

The ideas of deconstruction and reconstruction indicate a reorganisation of the process of creation, as consciousness is being constituted anew in the postindustrial age. It is not history itself that has ended, but traditional history. State, class, nation, party, society, family, morality, and marriage are all being defined afresh. As a consequence of so many changes, numerous institutions have become fragmented and stripped of their contexts.

Are there no good stories in Maithili, no good plays? Does Maithili have no grammar? Where in Maithili grammar does one find analyses of words such as *panisoh* and *panigar*? It is still the same old *anal* and *pāvak*! These points needed to be made in the context of Subhash Chandra Yadav's journey as a storyteller.

At a time when Maithili's problem is its expulsion from home after home, people who failed to make a name for themselves after dabbling in Hindi are turning to writing Maithili stories and poems and becoming editors and critics. They weigh down Maithili's literary atmosphere with their ambitions, stuffing Marxism, feminism, and secularism into stories and poems with relentless insistence. Such people have become arbiters of standards; ideological movements have turned into a fence around mediocrity.

Those engaged in exploiting and discouraging the poor and the lower castes seek refuge in Marxism; those who have insulted women seek refuge in feminism; and communalists seek refuge in secularism.

Indeed, communalists have been seen entering feminist circles, misogynists joining Marxist circles, and innumerable such alliances and literary establishments. Some devote themselves to praising Rajkamal,

others Yatri or Dhumketu, and in competing to determine what positions these writers should be assigned they thrust themselves into prominence. Claims that Yatri's *Paro* and the stories of Rajkamal and Dhumketu have still not been accepted—what baseless prattle!

Some edit supposedly controversial stories, manufacture controversies around them, and place themselves in the foreground. A confined competition centred on the writings of Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas is unsettling these poets and storytellers. After abandoning Hindi for Maithili, they have been performing such feats at such speed that one wonders when they will attend to Maithili's principal problems. Do they suppose that writing in Maithili after Hindi will win them immediate recognition? If Maithili writers suffer from such a delusion, from a lack of self-confidence, and from distrust of their mother tongue's communicative power (!), what pretence are we preserving by placing the language's future on their shoulders?

There were twenty writers of Maithili and five readers—what controversy could there have been? Having read Rajkamal's and Yatri's Maithili works, each of them, I can say that their writing is gentle in tone. In that situation, to introduce claims that a controversy existed in this poem or that story, and then polish one's own literary reputation by offering arguments for the claim—what sort of undertaking is that?

And then comes the claim that so-and-so is the first novelist after Yatri and someone-or-other the first poet after Rajkamal. Now pairs of storytellers and poets have also appeared, each devoted to the other and intent on advancing their mutual disputes.

Maithili's principal problem is that the language is dying amid the blows of the competing ambitions of this tiny circle of rivals (formidable rivals, indeed!). Poets and storytellers have made Maithili their career, reduced it to an object for seminars. Where, then, are the readers—and what controversies are we talking about?

The problem I see is how children may grow up in a Maithili-speaking environment, and how people of every caste may come to love the language. How far have stories and poetry advanced that cause? How many science-fiction stories, how many stories and poems for children and young people, are these career-minded poets and storytellers writing?

In an atmosphere of manoeuvring—printing one or two hundred copies of a book, arranging its review, getting it discussed in journals of similarly tiny circulation, assembling photocopies in a folder at home, and scheming to obtain awards or place books on syllabuses—my hopes have come to rest on readers and writers outside the Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha communities.

Those who could not manage their own homes and families have accumulated heaps of linguistic awards and set about creating a Mithila state. I do not know how they would manage a state.

They shamelessly accept awards for translations into Maithili from Marathi, Urdu, Tamil, and Kannada. Ask them the meaning of *vanakkam*, and they will not know it; they have no knowledge of *alif-be-se* and cannot even converse with a child in Marathi. And in Maithili they escape being challenged, because they get their own work printed and reviewed, while readers are absent. This absence of readers benefits them. When jurors and advisory-board members themselves step forward in the effort to promote their own interests in these awards, it only reveals how feeble the confidence of these limited competitors is.

How will those whose children have not entered literature be discussed in the future? Who will advance their case? This truth about Maithili literature needs to be exposed. Even while shutting their eyes to it, people are nevertheless searching for a solution.

The disciples and hangers-on of editors of collections of stories, poems, plays, and essays find places in Maithili's supposedly definitive anthologies. The condition of journals is much the same. These readerless journals, quarrelling over personal ambitions, are dying themselves and killing Maithili. In a language where folktales are written in drawing rooms without fieldwork, such absurd quarrels are only natural. Now, on some Maithili blogs on the internet, caste-based disputes and abusive language have also been observed.

Becoming Marxists or feminists and turning those labels into a trade, thereby making up for their own lack of literary quality, has become a weapon for poorly gifted writers in this restricted competition. Why would a person who respects Marx insist on announcing, "I am a Marxist critic" or "I am a Marxist writer"? What can one say of those who make a business of Marx? The reasons are also plain. National surveys show that Sanskrit, Hindi, Maithili, and other literatures are studied in colleges by those who cannot gain admission to other subjects; the same people also enter journalism. It is such talent-poor devotees who have acquired a taste for literary pursuits—and are we to believe the future of Maithili is safe in their hands? Yet, confronted with this reality, a road forward awaits us. A generation of genuine servants of Maithili—storytellers and readers willing to go into the dust and grime, to create literature for children and women, and to devote their energies simply to keeping Maithili alive—will surely arise.

No compromise in Maithili's name. Subhash Chandra Yadav's collection appeared serially online in the *Videha* e-journal (http://www.videha.co.in),

where it received the affection of thousands upon thousands of readers. The stories received online comments, and I inferred from the commenters' surnames that most were from outside the Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha communities. Another fact that emerged here is that differences between the pronunciation and reading of the language also arise from lack of education. This does not mean, however, that Yadavji still speaks the language of *Balchanma*. If we use that speech for a Yadav character in fiction today, it will sound like the Prakrit assigned to ordinary people amid the Sanskrit of the play *Śākuntalam*; people of that community may also find it insulting. Language is fluid, and the tradition of writing introduces a measure of stability into it. This distinction can also be clearly seen in Subhashji's language: between the language of his stories and that of his essays and other prose.

In her paper "Word, Dialogue and Novel", Julia Kristeva introduced the concept of intertextuality: a text cannot remain enclosed within four walls. She therefore describes a text as an assemblage.

Look now at *Gulo*: Naresh will distribute one thousand rupees for six votes on Ranjeeta Ranjan's behalf, but then he disappears. Phulwa will get Modi elected. It is an election for a Member of Parliament.

Subhash Chandra Yadav had thus found the context of his text in 2015. It must have continued to revolve within him, and in 2022 it emerged in expanded form in "Vote", alongside an election for a Member of the Legislative Assembly.

Thus intertextuality establishes an interdisciplinary subject matter. All these texts and subjects keep rubbing against one another, cancelling out one another's effects; sometimes one text comes to the fore, sometimes another. Nor can a text be separated from its social and cultural foundations. The sociocultural text and the literary text become intermingled.

A text is a subject of practice and production. The sociocultural text and the literary text already produce two different kinds of voices.

A text incorporates the conflicts and tensions of ideologies.

On Julia Kristeva's horizontal axis of relationships, there is a direct conversation between writer and reader: in other words, a conversation between the contents of an envelope and the address written upon it. On her vertical axis, however, a "text" converses with mainstream literature as well as with events occurring within a short period. That is to say, a text converses with its context, and one writer's text converses with another writer's text.

When these two axes intersect, a word or text comes into being within which at least one other text can be read.

Julia Kristeva describes the author's rights and duties in terms of preserving speech as it is and treating certain texts as something separate from human beings.

In "Word, Dialogue and Novel", Julia Kristeva advances Mikhail Bakhtin's concepts. She also analyses language through signs and symbols. When an infant communicates by means of signs and rhythm, there is neither structure nor meaning in that communication. But as the child grows, it begins to distinguish itself from others, begins to speak, and ventures beyond the courtyard. Thereafter it distances itself from the mother. Yet it does not move altogether away from the semiotic; rather, it continues to oscillate between the semiotic and the symbolic. The semiotic bears feminine qualities and is suffused with music, poetry, and rhythm; the symbolic has masculine qualities and is governed by rules and structure. Thus the devaluation of women's bodies and characters by men in films and other media arises from a fear that the mother's body threatens male existence. But the infant remains close to its mother and therefore remains more deeply connected with the feminine qualities of the semiotic—with music, poetry, and rhythm. It rejects the mother, yet defines itself through her.

Cornell supports, and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak welcomes, Jacques Derrida's intervention in feminist thought through his deconstructive theory centred on the feminine or the vagina. Where certain philosophical ideologies indirectly privilege the vagina, Derrida's drawing attention to the limitations of a vagina-centred standpoint constitutes a meaningful intervention. It has made it possible to redefine the constituents of the sign through a renewed process.

Derrida shows that dialogues between people cannot be factorised or reduced to simple components; they cannot be simplified. A woman should therefore not be regarded as an object of conjecture and knowledge. Feminism should not be understood only in relation to masculinity; a different idiom needs to be created for feminism itself.

Derrida says, roughly speaking, that a text is a political act that can be defined in terms of relations of power or negotiations over them. But he is accused of wanting men to appropriate women's voices, to take away the right to speak for themselves that women have gained with such effort. Derrida, according to this charge, has no concern for women's everyday problems and powerlessness. He takes deconstructive method in a positive, affirmative sense, while placing feminism within a metaphysical or logical binary of being—like man and woman.

Derrida exposes the fascination with centre-based structures in Western philosophy. Structuralism, inspired by Saussure's linguistics, attempts a scientific analysis of cultural existence. Lévi-Strauss's structural anthropology attempts the same for folktales and traditional narratives. Similarly, attempts have been made to analyse the structures of prose and poetry in literature. But Derrida exposes a difficulty here: structuralism seeks a firm foundation for its analysis, a centre outside the system from which the system may be analysed scientifically; yet that centre is no more than a philosophical appearance. How, for instance, could a folktale or folk narrative have one fixed or predetermined structure? To study its structure, you must first determine the idea or centre on the basis of which you intend to analyse it. Derrida says that a structure requires its governing concept or idea, after which its fragments may be assembled. Without thinking of the end, however, a structure cannot even be conceived. The same holds for literature. Unless you first find some supposedly self-evident meaning for a work, you cannot discover its structure, because meaning—the end—determines that structure. Thus a structuralist already knows the meaning and only then can analyse the various components and their mutual relations. For Derrida, that supposedly self-evident meaning, known before the analysis, is the centre. And, Derrida says, it determines how the reader constructs a structure, which components are included, and which are omitted. When analysing the structure of literature, we talk about its meaning and its effects, attempting to identify and distinguish those elements of the structure that produce the effects, while setting aside possible patterns that do not. This centre is thus the starting point for understanding the structure, but it also limits the analysis. To remain stable, the centre establishes and controls hierarchies. Moreover, this prior knowledge of meaning depends on the reader's previous history, contemporary critical theories, and ideologies. All these are themselves parts of culture. How, then, can we keep them outside the structure—while allowing them to restrict the structure without themselves being restricted by it? To make a permanent centre the foundation of analysis is therefore like prescribing a ready-made formula: a reactionary or status-quo position. It reveals only a desire to derive a normative, independently fixed meaning that cannot be comparatively tested. The belief that we are discovering a structure is an illusion; in reality we are constructing a structure out of textual materials.

Even Derrida's poststructuralism cannot begin without a centre. Yet on the basis of a deconstructive analysis of the unproven, supposedly self-evident premise, it replaces that centre with another; the new centre, too, will not remain permanent.

Similarly, in his theory of the sign, Saussure analyses signification by saying that a word such as “cat” means cat because it does not mean

something else. The word is the signifier, and what it indicates is the object or signified. Derrida, however, says that here too one must first introduce a concept. If you make the signifier absolute, with no relation to any signified—an independent concept in itself, without a direct relation to a signified or object—then all these concepts pass beyond the signifier and signify nothing at all. But if we treat signifier and signified as one and the same, we strike at the very roots of the signifier.

Thus Saussure's theory appears opposed to rationalism when he says that the signifier bears no inherent trace of the signified. But when he says that the signifier is employed solely to indicate the signified and is therefore subordinate to it, he seems to support a rationalist position. Derrida accordingly argues that this neat division between signifier and signified is untenable, and that the priority given to the signified over the signifier must also be overturned.

Meaning does not reside in the signifier from the outset. Nor can the whole of meaning be found in any single signifier. We must therefore churn and examine the text, which will drive us towards an endless search. A signifier determines what it signifies through its differences from other signifiers: the greater the differentiation, the nearer we move towards signification. Yet we can never discover every difference. A signifier must also be repeatable, even when one signifier comes to determine different signifieds. To understand this we need to know the written history of that signifier. It can therefore convey different meanings and sometimes even opposite meanings.

Derrida writes that from Plato to Saussure and Lévi-Strauss, thinkers have placed speech above writing, for writing is regarded as a medium while speech is taken as the real thing. Saussure draws attention to errors of pronunciation appearing in written forms. But Derrida argues that all the features attributed to speech also occur in writing. He goes further: the disappearance of the sign in speech produces the illusion that thought is directly present there. Yet if we record and replay spoken speech, it too is merely a chain of signs, like written letters, whose separate elements can be recognised through their differences from one another. Writing, likewise, may take the form of ordinary writing or writing that communicates by pictures. Behind all this lies a “metaphysics of presence”.

Central to Western philosophy's “metaphysics of presence” is immediate experience. Deconstruction, however, says that there is no such experience at a level beyond language, because experience is identified through language. Again, it is said that divine consciousness enables us to understand ultimate truth; deconstruction replies that this is only a creation of the creator. Again, it is claimed that truth lies concealed behind some object; deconstruction responds that there is no such

independent existence, for everything is constructed and reconstructed by a system. Thus Saussure's self-presence does not exist: everything is constituted within a system.

Derrida says that reason underlies all such philosophical thought, so an ultimate truth or universal spirit, presumed to know everything, is imagined. Yet Derrida says that this unproven centre has been called God at one time, Idea at another, and Universal Spirit at a third, and has created different levels beneath itself. Religion thus took God to be the ultimate truth and human beings and other creations to be imperfect and opposed to it. Each such centre claimed the power to create a system of ideas according to its own terms. Yet these centres would have to stand above the system: God, for instance, would have to exist independently outside religion. Poststructuralist deconstruction regards the presence of such a transcendent truth as an appearance produced by the poststructuralist theory of language. In the interplay of signifiers, some meanings gain a higher position through ideological intervention while other meanings are pushed into the background. Ideas such as freedom, republic, and justice are parts of our lives. It may seem that much of life's meaning comes from them, yet inquiry shows that they themselves emerge from other ideas. There is no concept in which the traces of another idea cannot be found.

Observe how *Gulo* begins. It opens on Til Sankranti: Gulo's youngest daughter Riniya is plastering the courtyard. Why does the novel begin with Riniya rather than Gulo's son? Because, according to Julia Kristeva, the son distances himself from the mother, whereas the daughter retains that rhythm and those qualities; even as she grows apart from her mother, she stays close to the mother and to culture. The novel could not have begun so beautifully in any other way. Riniya is singing; then come the dew, like a spray of water, the westerly wind, and the mother's anxiety: "Girl, put your shawl on!"

Later, too, the difference between daughter and son persists: "The girl keeps running about alone, now in the house, now in the orchard. The boy lies asleep until eight."

And then comes Kristeva's man, with his arrogance: "If you don't recognise me, then recognise me now."

Do we not see this arrogance in Lutyens' Zone? It is everywhere in human society, especially among male characters.

This self-absorption, in which writers review their own stories and poems, has arisen from the weakness of criticism. I feel disgust at this single, primary fact, and I see a remedy for the slow poisoning of Maithili in the Maithili literary movement of the *Videha* e-journal. The way readers and

writers from outside the Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha communities joined it, together with children and women, was extraordinary. Some will describe my emphasis on this point as an attempt to divide Maithili literature. But my priority is Maithili and its literary movement. If the language dies, what will become of the formidable editors, poets, storytellers, Mithila-state agitators, and critics sitting in their drawing rooms? The rereading of Subhash Chandra Yadavji's stories and of language itself draws me further towards his work in this way. It is also relevant here that his fiction continues to offer new rereadings of stories and of language. I hope this development will strengthen Maithili.

Now let us read all of Subhash Chandra Yadav's original works in succession ... *Ghardekhiya*.

Ghardekhiya contains thirty-five short stories. The tenth, "Kathak Banal Lok" ("A Man Made of Wood"), was included in *Galp Guchchha*, a story collection prescribed by the Bihar School Examination Board for Classes Nine and Ten. For that reason, it became the most popular and most widely read story in the collection, even more widely read than "Ghardekhiya" itself.

The publisher's note is by Madaneshwar Mishra, president of the Maithili Academy. He writes that the social class whose joys and sorrows, hopes and aspirations, indifference, anger, and social and economic circumstances Yadav depicts had until then remained almost neglected. He also observes that the stories are deeply moving, their style straightforward and lucid, and their language simple and intelligible to everyone.

1

Abhav (Deprivation, 1971)

An experiment in writing a literary composition, in trying several different ways of writing poetry. Subhash Chandra Yadav does not ordinarily write poems, but in this story, written in 1971, he has written three short poems that are in no way inferior to the poems in original and translated collections that have received Sahitya Akademi Awards:

First poem

> Upon my arms and back
> a badge that had been fastened
> began to spark like lightning.
> And I went on trembling,
> and in search of escape,
> from this corner to that,
> I kept running.
> Whichever room I entered,
> its walls began to blaze.

The moment I stepped out of the room,
the weather changed,
and I went on measuring, from desert to river,
the endless distance of mountains,
without end.

Second poem

Words never stood by me;
outside the context I intended,
rose the inaccessible mountains of meaning.
I remained unsuccessful
in reaching anywhere,
in a world of suffering,
at the beginning of life.

Third poem

I have arrived at that place
from whose turning point
the meanings of words
begin to assume altered shapes.

Yet his poetry did not advance beyond this. At that time he believed that an intense impulse born of sorrow was essential to poetic composition. He attempted to write satirical poetry, but only superficial indignation found expression.

This applies to many of the so-called satirists of today as well.

2

Asangati (Incongruity, 1978)

Kuki called out to him ... In his hands was a tray bearing two cups.

"Are you going to that side?"

Navin grew angry and said, "No." Yet he kept thinking that Kuki had noticed his bag and wanted to ask him to carry the cups away and put them down.

3

Anchar (The End of a Sari, 1969)

Again today there has been no respite—two successive downpours. "If the north-east wind blows in Ashwin, cows and farmers will weep in every home." Her husband says too, "It will neither speak nor bark; it will merely sit staring." Everyone's attention is fixed on her dry *anchar*, the end of her sari. Neither daughter nor son: what can she do? The sun had grown fierce. She felt as though she would have to pour water over the holy basil again ...

4

Uttar Megh (The Northern Cloud, 1972)

Five people—Mauji, Shibu, Kamu, Debu, and Vijendra. The story unfolds in their company.

Three women, all from the Musahar community; one of them an old woman. The daughter of the quarrelsome old woman has numerous scratches on her face. In the absence of a bodice and of care, both her breasts hang loose. Shibu, Kamu, and Vijendra stare at them. There is a domestic quarrel. The old woman gestures towards the husband, who is there too.

All five go on towards the fair.

Farther on they come upon an elderly man, who has returned after spying on a schoolmistress.

Next comes a dark-complexioned, middle-aged woman. She is wearing a yellow sari with a printed pattern and a red blouse. She goes into a room with a man.

A family gets off a train: three or four girls of approximately the same age. "Not one of them is any good!" says Kamu.

Most people have little idea what is happening around them or how others earn their living.

5

Ek Ta Dukhant Katha (A Tragic Story, 1977)

Sugiya's husband has gone elsewhere. She enters into a relationship with her younger brother-in-law and feels guilty. After a few days, everything begins again. Is it a sin or not a sin? That is her dilemma.

6

Ekta Prayog Ohina (An Experiment, Just Like That, 1970)

He has been sitting in a hotel for two hours, unable to make a decision, and has already drunk tea twice. Talk of education, politics, agriculture, unemployment, and numerous other contemporary matters continually strikes his ears. There might be twenty coins in his pocket. A friend had given him eight annas. He will go to his in-laws' house and ask for money. Apart from winter, he never used to visit them during the day. His in-laws live in a single room, so in winter they can sit on the roof even during daylight hours. His mother-in-law has sat down with a whole bundle of moral instruction.

7
Ek Ta Sambandhak Ant (The End of a Relationship, 1976)

The game begins: Pradip, Ragini Datta, and Vipul. Whoever loses will treat the others to kebabs, costing eight rupees. The narrator, "I," remains silent because he has no money. Pradip and "I" are on one side; Vipul and Datta on the other. Vipul is Datta's boyfriend, but the narrator finds his conduct strange and immature for a boyfriend.

8
Ek Dink Ghar (A Home for One Day, 1973)

Waiting for a train: when will it depart? And when it finally moves, it stops again at the outer signal.

Incidents of this kind used to occur, and still occur, on narrow-gauge trains and sometimes on broad-gauge ones too. On a bus, at least one can find out why it has stopped; on a train one cannot. The story offers a psychological analysis of this experience.

9
Kalpit Mrityu (Imagined Death, 1970)

A conversation between husband and wife; the wife goes when her father calls her. Her father will indeed give them money, but the husband resents his stipulation of a deadline for returning it. The wife asks what relationship would remain between the husband and her father if she herself died; as long as she is there, the connection exists. … "Would you marry my sister?"

10
Kathak Banal Lok (A Man Made of Wood, 1976)

The finest story in this collection. Rami goes to the block office to seek fifty rupees in assistance for a collapsed house. His son Badariya seems made of wood: even when beaten, not a single tear falls; his eyes are sunken, every bone in his chest stands out, he seldom speaks, does not play, and stares as though trying to remember something. But when Rami returns at night, that wooden Badariya asks, "Hey, Father, when did you come home?"

"My boy, you're awake! Come, come, sit by the fire. I've only just returned, son."

"Why didn't you come back in the evening?"

At his question, Belowali and Rami feel as though every grief and torment has been wiped away. For the first time that day, the two of them laugh freely.

11

Kono Patapar (To Some Address, 1974)

A letter to Pardeshi from his wife, the mother of four children, carrying both her message and her reproaches.

12

Gajkhor a Majmungar (The Gajkhor and the Majmungar, 1968)

In Bechani's marital home, everyone calls her husband a wastrel and speaks harshly to her as well, uttering words as coarse as yams. They call Bechani a *gajkhor* and her husband a *majmungar*.

13

Ghardekhiya (Bride Viewing, 1974)

The title story. Jagdish Prasad Mandal also wrote a story called "Ghardekhiya", first published electronically in *Videha* and later collected in *Gamk Jingi* (Village Life, 2009).

Bimla is entering her seventeenth year, though she does not look it: her face is gaunt. The prospective groom's family has come to see her. Everything can be arranged at little expense. They approve of the girl. The boy is not a driver but a truck cleaner. The girl has been approved. He has only recently returned to the village from Calcutta; to send word and summon him again immediately would incur expense. He will arrive ten days before the wedding; whoever wishes to see him may do so then.

14

Cheharapar Jamait Kuhes (Mist Settling on the Face, 1972)

The protagonist (narrator) and the little girl. "I'll leave the door open tonight," the narrator says, but then forgets what he has said.

"The door was open; what if a dog had come in?"

"It was open!" The protagonist (narrator) can scarcely believe it.

15

Chaubatiya (Crossroads, 1969)

The protagonist (narrator) sits in a hotel, holding his head in hunger. He goes to his village. His uncle has his own story: for three months they have eaten nothing but bread, not even glimpsing rice. The protagonist becomes angry: he has fathered so many children, an entire crowd, and still has not learned restraint. The uncle imagines that the protagonist is flush with money. He asks for cash and, about the old debt, says that he has cultivated jute on a sharecropping basis and will sell it and repay him. For now he asks for ten rupees. But the protagonist himself sometimes passes two successive evenings hungry for want of money. He leaves without

eating. He asks a friend for cash; although that friend has lent him money before, now, even when asked for four annas, he gives nothing. Another friend, Yadunandan, had been unable to return one rupee for two years; he slips away to one side. The protagonist does not even ask a third friend, Kalicharan. Back at the hotel, perhaps the staff have forgotten his very old unpaid bill, but now another boy is sitting there. … What a comfortable crossroads this is!

16

Jasus Kukur a Chor (The Detective Dog and the Thief, 1973)

A theft, a report to the police station, and corruption. The police inspector asks for money in the name of procuring a detective dog: the dog will catch the thief. A constable demands five hundred rupees, and an agreement is reached at three hundred. But what of the dog?

17

Jhali (The Net, 1973)

The rice harvest. Rama has not managed to bathe today, and his craving begins to torment him. Cannabis … Laramaha in the Dusadh settlement … "Four chillums and it has all gone up in smoke," says Bindua. The trade in the Dusadh neighbourhood: women and girls lay out coal during the day and even in the early morning. The men will be occupied selling cannabis in daytime, the girls at night. That scoundrel of an inspector arrives and swiftly pockets fifty rupees. … Cannabis with long matted leaves produces intoxication very quickly.

There is a drug trade among African Americans in the United States too. Do you see any resemblance?

18

Tip (The Tip, 1974)

The pleasure of leaving a tip in a hotel—and what happens when no tip is given?

19

Dar (Fear, 1969)

An analysis of the psychology of fear.

20

Tirth (Pilgrimage, 1969)

The story of Balbabali's household. No doctor will call her mad … yet she is mad. Ever since she came to her husband's home after marriage, she has been afflicted by a spirit. "Look at Kusuma. Will you people ever be her equal?" And so Kusuma has become Balbabali. She has four children, yet each time she is confined after childbirth she receives only millet bread

and greens. Her brother-in-law has not given her any money, but she will still take her mother-in-law on pilgrimage and show him what she can do. She asks the protagonist (narrator) for a little money. His hands are empty; he cannot get any. But she is determined to go to Baidyanathji. What would the cost of one or two *sers* of flattened rice amount to? She will show that wretched brother-in-law. … Yet going off in a great clatter and commotion would not be right, so she does not go.

21

Dhundh Me Ghatna (An Event in the Mist, 1970)

The story has a first, second, and third situation, then two reports from its arranger, and finally its concluding situation.

In the first situation there is an east or west wind, perhaps brushing the emotions, perhaps not; the atmosphere of a tin-roofed house, a gulmohar tree, grass, and *dūb* grass.

In the second situation it is evening: a heron's nest and a spider's web, old meaningless papers. After spending the day turning over files, a man has left his room for the market.

The third situation concerns a woman who left the room before the story began, and all that would happen if she were to return.

Before the final situation come two reports: the first about Prakash, afflicted with filariasis—swelling of the limbs—and the second about a dead child emerging from the womb.

In the story's final situation, the road is called a "prostitute road," perhaps because it is trampled underfoot. The feet are numb and heavy, while fragments of sentences come together as consolation. But the protagonist (narrator) wants a crowd and light. To run away after coming halfway would be pointless.

Then there is the image of a dried-up stream, with someone standing upon its embankment. Mist everywhere: neither village, nor people, nor light. All these things lie a short distance away in every direction, but for now they are meaningless. For now the mist and the void resemble death.

Does this not remind you of Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot*?

22

Dhukkad (Dhukkad, 1970)

The departure time of the bus is unknown. Will the bus remain here all day? Everyone cheats the conductor, the protagonist (narrator) included. Very few tickets are booked.

But the narrator never meets that conductor again; perhaps he has left the job.

23

Parichay (Introduction, 1971)

Netaji urges the protagonist (narrator) to visit his house, and makes him understand that he has done him a favour. But when, tired and defeated, the protagonist takes his leave, his companion insists on attending the evening performance of a theatre company—and there, Netaji …

24

Pet (The Stomach, 1971)

"Kalim!" He disappears into the crowd. Three hours earlier he had called out to Vinay, but Vinay paid no attention. Hunger … One gives an order at the hotel but can manage to ask only for water. The neighbourhood is quieter than in the day. Someone has left the tap beside the wall running. Its noise is unbearable, yet one knows that in the morning there will be even greater noise.

25

Fansari (The Noose, 1969)

Bhelbabali Kaki is more than a hundred years old. Her eyesight is weak, probably from cataracts, and she can see only shadows. The imagery of the month of Kartik occurs in this story too. The rice harvest comes in Agahan; the month before it—Kartik, the eleventh month after the previous Agahan—is extremely difficult, with an acute shortage of money. Kaki goes to the protagonist (narrator), calling for lime to prepare tobacco, complaining noisily since morning. For two or three days she has been crying out about nothing but lime: only if there is lime can anyone give her tobacco to chew. The protagonist brings her a little lime and even mixes her chewing tobacco. She looks for the master of the house, her son, who was supposed to go to Supaul but is still here. Her head keeps aching. Her daughter-in-law thinks she is complaining about her and cannot bear it, but the old woman's hearing is weak too, so she does not hear. If she dies now, how will the funeral feast be managed? There are twenty-two complications, the protagonist tells her. For three or four days Kaki has kept a noose around her neck; once she even swallowed poison, yet she has not died. How could she have died when the noose had never been tightened?

26

Phukna (Balloons, 1970)

The protagonist (narrator) is at his maternal uncle's village, but he notices that people there treat him in two different ways. Instead of taking his ease

after returning from school, he goes on scratching at the courtyard. When he abuses his sister-in-law, she warns him that she is no indulgent younger sister-in-law: with one slap she will redden his face. His grandmother protects him, although both her hearing and her eyesight are poor. He begins repairing a bicycle, and a ball bearing flies away. In exchange for the ball bearing he recovers, he buys three dozen balloons. Ravinder gets some balloons, but there is a hole in his pocket. Ravinder refuses to admit it, and the protagonist beats him. He remembers his father. He asks his grandmother, "When will Father come?"

27

Banjh (Barren, 1968)

The month of Sawan. Mud everywhere, in the courtyard and at the doorway; water dripping from the eaves. It is Dukhni's first Sawan, and yet they have left her at her in-laws' house? That is what the woman from Rampur asks Dukhni's mother. Only one and a half *bighas* of land remain, and even that is coveted by the relatives. Her husband's death, the trouble of arranging Dukhni's marriage; a dilapidated hut and the cry, "Keep Mother Sita's skull! Keep it!" Four people are removed. Dukhni's mother lies dead. By chance Dukhni runs home that very evening. The Rampur woman spreads the news among the other women. "These things do happen," she says; "Give up your fields, but not your homestead." Dukhni departs. At her aunt's home she is treated with great affection, but she cannot understand the selfish motives of her aunt and uncle. Then rumours begin to spread, and the aunt asks why nobody comes from Dukhni's marital home.

"They think I am barren."

Her uncle and aunt get her land transferred into their names. If anyone asks, they will say that the money was spent on her marriage. They will find an elderly bridegroom, and on top of the marriage expenses they will obtain another five hundred rupees.

28

Ber-Ber (Again and Again, 1979)

Harivansh and Raghuvansh have bought first-class tickets covering more than half the distance. Ten stations remain to be crossed. But a ticket examiner catches Harivansh, who is sent to jail. One day Raghuvansh comes and pays his fine.

29

Mahima (Glory, 1975)

The police arrest Sukhdev during a meeting and take him to prison. He is released after a month; he had been detained under MISA.

For some time he had been a Naxalite and had previously spent eight days in jail for cutting a government embankment.

He had swindled several people out of money during an election.

There is much quarrelling and fighting; if there is nobody else, he beats up the woman from Narkatiya. If nothing else, he must at least have returned from jail with clothing worth four hundred rupees.

30
Ramnihor (Ramnihor, 1975)

Ramnihor, a mess-hall assistant, sends two hundred rupees each month to a woman in Faizabad district. Borrowing a holdall from the protagonist (narrator), he goes to his village on ten days' leave. Ten days have passed; he may return by evening. There is no need to worry so much about the holdall.

31
Lift (A Lift, 1980)

Taking a lift with Mrs Kapoor proves costly for Manoj, because she knows Diwakar. Why did Manoj get into her car when Diwakar was there?

32
Sanket (A Sign, 1974)

"There are six seats in Room Number Nine. Let him get up and you can spread your bedding. Though someone will be sleeping there, anyway."

33
Saharsa Dupahar Rati (Saharsa at Midnight, 1972)

Subhash, Mahaprakash, and Sukant. Sukant wants to escape the crowd; Subhash cannot make up his mind. Mahaprakash does not need to think so much. Subhash wants to throw a burning cigarette stub onto a girl's back. The police arrest all three for roaming about at night.

34
Sigaret (Cigarette, 1969)

A craving for a cigarette. He sends the servant to fetch some, but the servant smokes the master's half-smoked cigarette instead. Then an acquaintance, a little cunning, and a packet of Wills Filter turn up.

35
Surang (The Tunnel, 1972)

The protagonist (narrator) and Kishori Bhai arrive at the home of Sheila and her engineer husband. Has the engineer begun to suspect Sheila's relationship with Kishori Bhai? Why did Sheila begin living at her parents'

home? Beni is a year and a half old. In a letter the protagonist had read, Sheila asked what vengeance he wanted to take by snatching milk and biscuits from an innocent child. Yet there, the engineer is playing with the baby.

The engineer works at a lamp factory. When taking his leave, Kishori Bhai hands the protagonist a sixty-watt lightbulb. Later the protagonist discovers that it has fused, and Kishori Bhai asks him to have it exchanged.

Consider the themes of the stories in *Ghardekhiya*. Consider the portrait of Badariya (made of wood, not shedding a single tear even when beaten, with sunken eyes and every bone in his chest visible; he speaks little, never plays, and stares as though trying to remember something), the story of an extramarital relationship, the poverty of the protagonist, and the episodes of quarrelling and bickering. Subhash himself appears in several stories, and in one, "Saharsa Dupahar Rati" (1972), Subhash, Mahaprakash, and Sukant all appear together.

Nit Naval Rajkamal (A Monograph on Rajkamal)

[*The monograph on Rajkamal Chaudhary was rejected by the Sahitya Akademi in January 1997; it appeared in the December 2005 –March 2006 issue of *Rachana* and was published in 2022 under the title *Nit Naval Rajkamal**.]

"I had heard something of the Rajkamal-ji (*Vinibandh*) episode, though that was many years ago now. But it is only from your account that I have realised just how ugly it was. For this I thank you, Gajendra-ji. The truth, however, is that my mind became disenchanted before I had finished reading it all. I could not read any further! You did well to put it on the internet. Let the contemporary generation and those to come understand this dark story too! Consider the predicament of people like me: this entire episode involves my younger friends, friends of my own generation, and elders. It has turned into an historical calamity! I am not personally responsible for any part of it. And yet, as a member of that literary generation, I am condemned to bear a sense of 'guilt' on moral grounds. What remedy is there?—With affection, Gangesh Gunjan, 11 September 2012 (*Videha* 117)."

The monograph on Rajkamal was rejected in January 1997 by the Maithili department of the Sahitya Akademi, through the machinations of Mohan Bhardwaj and with the cooperation of Rajmohan Jha. For that act, the author alleges, Rajmohan Jha was honoured in 1997 with the Akademi's original-work award for Maithili for 1996. Mohan Bhardwaj, who had overseen the act, was also made a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board.

Nit Naval Rajkamal (The Life of Rajkamal) is dedicated to: the devout Santosh Kumar Kundan, Suvrata, Girivar, Krishna; Radhe Radhe.

Nit Naval Rajkamal — A Hero of Legend

Rajkamal Chaudhary (Manindra Narayan Chaudhary, popularly known as Phool Babu), 1929–1967, Mahishi, Saharsa. His works include *Adi Katha*, *Andolan* and *Pathar Phool* (novels), *Swaragandha* (a poetry collection), *Lalka Pag* (a story collection), and *Katha Parag* (an edited collection of stories).

The earthquake, the Bengali woman ascetic and the picture of the *Raslila* are based on Rajkamal's autobiographical statements. He remembered the earthquake of 1934: the earth cracked and rumbled, and his mother and father, preoccupied with saving their own lives, left him behind.

A few days after the earthquake, a Bengali woman ascetic arrived. Rajkamal's mother had met her at a place of pilgrimage. The ascetic asked him to go with her, and he, too, wished to accompany her.

He saw a picture of a *Raslila*, with Krishna and several *gopis*.

Rajkamal gave wide publicity to these episodes. Everyone seeks some pretext through which to present a personality or an ideology. This was also a marketing strategy on Rajkamal's part.

Nit Naval Rajkamal — Life

Nothing especially unusual: his father's first wife had no children, so he married again (Rajkamal's mother came from Rampur Haveli). His mother died, and his father married a second and then a third time, the latter marriage being to a young woman of Rajkamal's own age. Rajkamal called his father, Madhusudan Chaudhary, 'Lal Kakka'. One daughter from the third marriage, Madalasa, survived, and Rajkamal was fond of her. His father initiated him into Brahmanical rites and values through commands, admonitions and beatings. Before passing the matriculation examination, Rajkamal had memorised every verse of the *Gita* and the *Durga Saptashati*. Following his father's transfers, he moved from place to place; from Nawada he came to Patna and enrolled at B. N. College. His father supplied him with 442 prohibitory injunctions—an entire catalogue of things he must not do.

Love affairs: his first romantic relationship was with Shobhana Jha in Patna. He failed the Intermediate Commerce examination once and later failed the B.Com. examination once. In 1951 he married Shashikanta of Chanpura, Darbhanga. His formal studies ended after the B.Com.

After his marriage he worked for a while as a proofreader at a newspaper in Patna, then as a lower-division clerk in the Secretariat. Darbhanga, Patna,

Delhi, Mussoorie, and then Calcutta followed. From there he corresponded with Savitri Sharma of Mussoorie and married her in 1956. He then fell in love with a woman named Santosh (probably Savitri's niece), and on 3 July 1957 fled Mussoorie, leaving Savitri while she was pregnant. There followed three or four months in Patna, Darbhanga and Nawada, and then Calcutta, where he went bearing a letter from Yatri addressed to the Hindi writer Chhedilal Gupta. He became associated with Babu Saheb Chaudhary's *Mithila Darshan*, and later with Bharatiya Jnanpith in Calcutta; his wife was with him. Subsequently he left his job and brought out *Ragarang*, but it closed down. During his six years in Calcutta he wrote a great deal of literature. His body grew weak; the lump on his abdomen had first appeared in Calcutta.

Then Delhi.

He corresponded with Kirti Narayan Mishra, Jivakant and Hansraj.

Then, in October 1963, he settled in Patna.

In 1966, Shashi, Divya, Mukta and Neelu came from Nawada to see him.

He corresponded with Alka of Banaras; this was his last love affair. In the first week of November 1966 he went to Banaras to meet her.

The Marxist critic Namvar Singh did not consider him worth even a postcard. In *Nayi Kahaniyan*, a statement by Madhukar Gangadhar appeared, alleging that although Rajkamal was undergoing treatment for an illness, he was invoking poverty and neglect as a pretext to extort money from people. By writing letters, he also incited Prakash Jain, editor of *Lahar*, and Manmohini against Rajkamal. Rajkamal wrote in his diary: "Madhukar and *Lahar* people have joined hands in dirty propaganda against me."

One day Dr Chaturvedi told him that he might have urethral cancer in his penis, and that, if this proved to be the case, the penis might have to be amputated. Rajkamal wrote in his diary: "If I have to cut my penis, I will commit suicide."

Chandramauli and Upadhyay were the two people who cared for him most, including by providing financial assistance. Long after Rajkamal's death, both died by suicide. Rajkamal dedicated his *Dehgatha* to the two of them. Hansraj and Alok Dhanwa came to see him in hospital. Four of Rajkamal's brothers lived in Patna, and three had jobs, yet not one of them took the trouble to bring even a paisa's worth of medicine.

He died in June 1967.

Nit Naval Rajkamal — Maithili Literature

Rajkamal wrote a hundred poems, three novels, thirty-seven stories, three one-act plays and four critical essays. *Swaragandha* collects poems he wrote during his stay in Calcutta between November 1957 and April 1958. He considered Yatri contemporary but not modern. Rajkamal wrote the novels *Andolan*, *Pathar Phool* and *Adi Katha*. *Lily Rek Rangin Parda* reminded him of Émile Zola's novel *Lajja*. Because of his traditionalist thinking, Ramanath Jha declared Rajkamal's entire literary craftsmanship artificial.

Banait Bigarait (Making and Unmaking)

In most of the stories in Subhash Chandra Yadav's collection *Banait Bigarait*, we find that the narrative advances with a theme rather than with an elaborate anecdotal plot, and comes to an end as soon as its task is done. Its language is another distinctive feature. The language of *Balchanma* is the autobiographical speech of that novel's principal character; here, by contrast, the language belongs to the storyteller himself and acquires a character of its own. Subhash-ji's refusal to follow the convention of turning stories into didactic tales, his practice of taking a theme forward within carefully defined limits, and his attention to a craft of language that is authentically indigenous—all these factors together will give one class of readers immense pleasure in these stories. At the same time, the collection will not disappoint readers who have not yet moved beyond traditional tales and anecdotes; rather, it will refine their taste.

A few questions concerning the standardisation of language: for instance, *aichh*, *achhi* and *a i chh*. These deserved attention when standardisation was taking place. We might, for example, write *jait rahi* as *jati rahi* and then devise a rule of pronunciation for *jati* (*ja-i-t*); the relation of *aichh* to *achhi* raises a similar issue. But it is now rather late. The writer himself points towards a solution by employing one such form in *Kaniya-Putara*, only to revert to the earlier forms in his other stories. Still, this demonstrates the need to establish a standard form. If we decide to write *chhai*, that is fine; and if we decide upon *chhaik*, let us formulate a pronunciation rule specifying that the final *k* is silent. What I consider necessary is that this should be done quickly and become generally acceptable. People today do not have their whole lives to spend quarrelling over whether to write *ya* or *e*. Accept what phonological theory tells us: *ya* is a consonant and *e* a vowel; the universal substitution of one for the other is impossible. And if a substitution is to be made, establish a rule of pronunciation. Writing *nañi* for *nahi* is intelligible, but among *naĩ* (Antika), *naim* (NBT) and *nãi* (Saketananda, *Kalaratrishcha Daruna*),

Saketananda's usage proves more appropriate according to phonetic principles. If there is doubt, seek the assistance of phonetics laboratories.

One feature of *Banait Bigarait* is that Subhash Chandra Yadav has employed his own distinctive, phonetic mode of writing, one capable of carrying the debate on standardisation forward.

Subhash-ji belongs to the generation of storytellers that emerged after Independence. He gives form to life through the short story, enriching it through both technique and subject matter, and thereby making it meaningful. Naturally, his stories depict the struggle of ordinary people for existence. Perhaps Badariya, the character in his story *Kathak Banal Lok* ("People Made of Wood"), written several decades ago, continued to smile by coincidence. The characters of this collection, too, possess similar traits. One character falls asleep while weeping in hospital and, on waking, begins to cry again; another is in love. Some have a business instinct, while there are also characters like Harivansh, whose acts of apparent kindness end in harm because of systemic failure. Let us now examine the stories of *Banait Bigarait* closely.

Kaniya-Putara: in this story a little girl in the street clasps the writer's feet and then rests her head against his knee, utterly at ease, as though she had laid her head in her mother's lap. Something firm, like a lemon, brushes against him. It is the girl's breast. She remains unperturbed, as if she were leaning against her father, grandfather, brother or sister. The writer wonders: will she become Sita or Draupadi? The spectres of Ravana and Duryodhana surround him.

After reading *Kaniya-Putara*, the crossroads are the same, and the children are the same children one sees while stopping and starting a vehicle at a traffic signal. Yet one's way of seeing changes. Earlier, one might have driven away without a second thought after giving—or not giving—money to children who wipe car windows and beg. Can that vision remain unchanged after reading *Kaniya-Putara*? A boy may grow up to steal or become a foot soldier at the lowest rung of some drug cartel; but a girl? Will she become Sita, Draupadi or Amrapali? Those social institutions and human-rights organisations that, when a lover climbs an electricity pole and threatens to kill himself, spread a net below and publicise themselves and their organisations before television cameras—can they continue to work with the same old outlook after reading this story? A government that merely renames a hospital after Jayaprakash Narayan, or Hardinge Park after Veer Kunwar Singh, and considers its duty discharged—will it instead reach the roots of the problem and build a new hospital and a new park in those names, or simply stamp 'Made by Me' on somebody else's work? Will these institutions not abandon their long-standing habit of avoiding hard work and seeking easy solutions?

Asurakshit ("Unsafe"): this story vividly portrays how perilous the twenty-minute walk home from the railway station has become at night. It was not like this earlier: the change reflects a condition of people's minds. Yet who pays attention to problems of this sort? The media concentrate on great issues—liberalisation and any number of other subjects. Here the everyday problems of streets and intersections are seen afresh. In the darkness of night, the distance from the station to home assumes the proportions of a mountain. The story is also a commentary on the state of law and order in the region at that time.

Ekaki ("Alone"): Kusesar is in hospital. The hospital itself is described vividly. There a woman, crying after her husband's death, apparently falls asleep in tears; when she wakes, she begins crying again. This is how life is. The storyteller points towards a truth of human existence and comments on the conditions and management of the hospital not through overt declaration but by showing life as it is lived.

O Larki ("That Girl"): amid the hostel lives of young men and women, a young man named Navin sees a girl holding an empty, used cup belonging to her and her boyfriend. She asks Navin where he is going. Navin assumes that she considers him beneath her and has asked him to throw away the cup. He refuses. Thoughts whirl in his mind. The story rests upon this small occurrence: had she really considered him inferior and asked him to dispose of her tea cup? Having said a firm 'No', he moves on. Like *Ekaki*, this story is based upon psychological analysis.

Ekta Prem Katha ("A Love Story"): in the days when few households had a telephone, calls would arrive at one person's house with the request that a neighbour be summoned. The writer had a telephone at home and would call a young man whenever the young man's girlfriend telephoned him. The young man then bought a mobile phone, and the calls stopped. But after he changed his number, the girlfriend again began calling the writer's house. The girlfriend, Ritu, was a friend of the young man's maternal cousin; the writer grew anxious to help her. In this story the lovers, mobile phone and telephone enter the new short story as naturally as they have entered the new age.

The title story is *Banait Bigarait*. It has three named characters: Mala, her husband Satto and their granddaughter Muniya. The exchanges between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law in a village household have become so strained that one might not even ask the other to eat after bathing. Yet when that same son and daughter-in-law move away, the mother-in-law begins to worry even about the cawing of a crow. The story depicts the reality of the village after migration. One day the crow, too, will disappear along with Satto, and Muniya will search for both the crow and her grandfather. It is a story of migrants, of the son and daughter-in-law and

the granddaughter, of conflict and love between mother-in-law and daughter-in-law.

In *Apan-Apan Dukh* ("Each One's Sorrow"), a wife, feeling neglected, curses her children. At night the children eat, and after they have eaten the kitchen is locked; the wife remains hungry, and naturally the sound of her husband's snoring irritates her. Everyone inhabits a world of their own. Each person thinks that the happiness and suffering of that personal world encompass everything, but that is not so. Everyone has distinct joys and sorrows, hopes and aspirations. The storyteller discloses a truth that falls within his own experience. How could the environment of inward experience be wholly independent? This question comes to the surface throughout Subhash Chandra Yadav's stories.

In *Atank* ("Terror"), the storyteller meets his old friend Harivansh in an office. The writer's land-mutation application remains unfinished because, after Harivansh's transfer, nobody took a bribe from him and consequently nobody did the work. Harivansh's liberality had arisen from the illicit income of bribes; why should another official surrender his own opportunity to earn? The writer is terror-stricken. The office environment, corruption and the way social relations change when a single official is transferred are all expressed here. Even today, when you or I go to a block office or the Secretariat for some work, are we not told: 'Pay whatever they ask, and if there is any problem afterwards, tell us'? If you come with somebody's name or recommendation instead of cash, the employee will neither receive the money nor get your work done.

In *Ekta Ant* ("An Ending"), the writer's co-brother (the husband of his wife's sister) has shaved his head after their father-in-law's death, while the writer has not; this provokes all kinds of comments. The other man is at ease because he has had his hair cut. Here cultural symbolism enters: the person who is caught is branded a thief and wrongdoer, while the one who escapes detection is held to be idealistic. Not entirely, but something of this kind of faith arises and breaks apart in this story too. In Haryana, people do not necessarily shave their heads even when their own fathers die: does that mean their grief is any less? In Punjab, a woman does not wear vermilion or bangles until a year after her marriage, while during the first year she wears bangles up to her shoulders. Does her love for her husband diminish after that first year?

In the story *Kabachhu*, a masseur comes to the writer and rests a hand on his thigh. Because people of refined, elite upbringing are sitting nearby, the writer removes the hand. The masseur asks what embarrassment there can be about touching a body that has already been touched. It is as though the masseur imagines the writer has mistaken him for a young woman. The writer feels as if he himself were a woman and the masseur an

old lover. The masseur lacks any delicate awareness of place and time: otherwise the writer would have allowed himself a massage even in such heat. He feels sorry for the masseur's wretched circumstances, yet remembers his drawn-out 'Shee-ee-ee' with revulsion. Freud's psychoanalysis has often been attacked for placing sex at the centre of its account. Yet experience suggests that the more one distances oneself from sex, the more one excludes it from conversation, stories and literature, the fiercer its return becomes.

In *Karbar* ("Business"), the writer meets Mr Verma, Sinha and two other people. In a bar, Sinha distinguishes friendship from business and relates two stories. Everything has its price. One story, about buying a television for a friend's wife only to receive a demand for a refrigerator, breaks off midway. In the other, a woman approaches a former lover for money to pay a doctor's fee and save her husband's life. The former lover asks her to spend the night with him in exchange for the money. Sinha does not consider anyone at fault: why should a doctor treat a patient without payment? Why should a former lover hand over money for nothing? And if the woman refuses to spend the night with him, her husband will die.

Now, when the writer leaves the bar and the doorman salutes him, he begins to hear the ring of money even in that salute. The collapse of older values, friendships and ideals gives rise to a sense of solitude.

Freud comes to the fore again in *Kushti* ("Wrestling"). The story begins with a stiff, dried stain on a *lungi*. But it soon becomes clear that the mark is not what it at first appears to be; it is the mark of a wound. We then hear of village problems being settled at a wrestling match in the market, of the health centre remaining closed, and of bricks being stolen from there. The younger brother, in the course of treatment, loses faith in allopathy and begins trusting homoeopathy instead. People come to enquire about the wound, and the writer gives them detailed accounts, while putting off several younger visitors. These successive incidents build an atmosphere.

In *Canary Island ke Laurel* ("The Laurel of the Canary Islands"), Subhash and Upiya are the characters. There is an image here: a decision is like the collapsing bank of the Kosi. A letter from a maternal cousin; setting out in a boat with a dagger; entering a current of ochre-coloured water; disembarking on a *chhit*, a raised patch of land amid the river; and finding thigh-deep water still stretching far beyond that patch. Seeing him push a bicycle through scorching sand, somebody remarks: 'Did your in-laws give you that bicycle? Give it a little prod, the way you would urge on a bullock.' At his elder sister and brother-in-law's home he hears how their daughter's wedding had been delayed for two days over the demand for a coat, and how excessive education is supposed to drive people mad. Although Subhash wants to, he cannot bring himself to ask for two

hundred rupees. His sister's behaviour remains ambiguous; unconvinced and uneasy, Subhash goes back.

In *Trishna* ("Longing"), the writer meets Akhilan, who tells him about his encounter with Shrilata. When he returns on the fifth day, she is not on the train. What is Akhilan to do now—keep travelling the route between Visakhapatnam and Vijayawada, or spend his days in the company of a memory?

The Laurel of the Canary Islands and *Trishna* analyse small incidents charged with emotion.

In *Dana* ("Grain"), Mohan goes for a job interview. A sympathetic peon informs him that outsiders are not selected; a PhD might have made a difference. Everything seems sick and sorrowful to Mohan. Sparrows and mynas chirp and dart towards crumbs of bread. The story sensitively describes the distinction between the 'outside' candidate and the 'local' one at an interview in a competitive selection process.

In *Drishti* ("Vision"), there is the search for employment after finishing one's studies, and the sharp taunts of fellow villagers. Then, encouraged by a South Indian journalist, the writer takes up farming in his village despite his wife's objections. Though this is an ordinary subject, social truths are exposed at various points. We see the malicious gossip of village people, encouraged by the ample idle time produced by lack of work. Alongside it appears the aspiration of present-day women to live an urban life.

In *Nadi* ("River"), the subject moves forward with the story and comes to an end with it. Bihari has come to Gagandev's home; he is to stay in the city for a year. While helping him look for a house, Gagandev meets a girl. He leaves her behind and walks on, yet even knowing that he will never meet her again, he feels a surge of joy and love.

Paralay ("Deluge") is a story of flooding, and here the flood is the Kosi's. Bauki is waiting for Bunachhek. But the water in the river channel keeps rising. The swelling Kosi flood is approaching, while Bauki is worn out by his mother's incessant demands and troubles. The cattle are bellowing from hunger. Ramcharan has more food and water at his house, and Bauki asks everyone to arrange a boat. The erosion was still some distance from Bauki's home. Death and destruction have made him hard and broken his attachments. But then the rain stops. Bauki begins trying to recognise and remember the things around him.

In *Bat* ("A Matter"), the storyteller again finds his plot while moving along a road and develops it through his craft. At a lemon seller's stall, the writer hears a quarrel between the vendor and another man and joins in. The customer is asking the seller for an umbrella that he had left beneath

the stall. According to the writer, people remember sorrowful things for a long time.

Rambha rapidly portrays changes in relations between men and women. So long as a man remains distant from women, every woman seems to him a Menaka or Rambha. But once conversation begins, the writer later feels that she might as well be his daughter. A woman approaches along the road. The writer wonders who she is—Rambha, Menaka, or someone else. She has a son with her and is not exceptionally beautiful; the writer reasons that her husband therefore cannot have been handsome either. During their conversation she sometimes addresses him as though he were her father-in-law, and at other times compares herself to his daughter. The writer initially dislikes this but later feels pleased. At the end, however, he cannot understand why she bends down as if to touch his feet and then straightens without touching them.

In *Hamar Gam* ("My Village"), the writer describes the roads of his village, the scattering of villagers from Kataniya to Menahi, and people wandering between the embankments. The people of the Kosi region live like animals, in conditions scarcely better than those of animals. The writer's house at Kataniya was washed away by erosion, and he is therefore staying with Nathuniya. Nathuni makes arrangements for fishing and trapping birds. A land dispute is under way: one co-sharer's land has disappeared beneath the river, so he wants to seize the writer's wheat field. People are distracted by wealth and women (!).

The writer has begun pursuing women without any good reason, rather as Vishnu Sharma, while narrating the tales of the *Panchatantra*, turns against Shudras and women.

While everyone sits beside Kamal's fire, drinking tea in turns because there are too few cups, the harvested crop is carried away to Sibanan's place. When there were thickets of *jhaua*, *kaṡ* and *pater*, birds used to arrive in great numbers; now fewer come. *Khariya*, deer, fish, turtles and *doka* are disappearing: the means of sustaining life have grown scarce. In the evening a village council meets to settle the land dispute. Satto's goat has died; the daughter-in-law attributes its death to the mother-in-law's curses, while the mother-in-law says that it happened because the sacrificial young goats were sold off even after the vow of sacrifice had been made. The writer interprets the signs of Satto's daughter's emerging youth as evidence of contact with a man and, for a reason, once more turns his suspicions upon women, since this belief is current among the people. Satto's daughter does not yet live with her husband's family. While eating at Sukan Ram's house, the writer feels embarrassed and, to overcome his discomfort, says: 'Today I have made you one of my caste.' The Kosi has

erased every distinction: Doms, Chamars, Musahars, Dusadhs, Telis and Yadavs all draw water from the same vessel and sit on the same mat.

Gulo (Hindi Translation)

[*Based on the text of the Hindi translation of *Gulo*, published by Antika Prakashan.*]

First, a comment on the Hindi translation of *Gulo*. (For the theoretical discussion, see my book *A Theory of Translation for Maithili and a Criticism of Translated Literature*, in *Maithili Samikshashastra*, available in the Videha repository at http://www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm.)

Suppose you have watched a hit film such as the Kannada *Kantara* in a PVR cinema. Would you then be able to watch even five minutes of it on an OTT platform?

When Harimohan Jha's son Rajmohan Jha saw Vibha Rani's Hindi translation of *Kanyadan*, he was so distressed that he held his head in his hands. The novelist Vikram Chandra was similarly distressed by Anurag Kashyap's inferior web-series adaptation of *Sacred Games*. Reading the Hindi translation of *Gulo* gave me the same feeling.

People of the mainstream translate without having studied translation theory. When the original writing of mainstream Brahminist and neo-Brahminist authors already suffers from an impoverished vocabulary, what can be said of their translations? The translator, Raman Kumar Singh, possesses neither an adequate Maithili vocabulary nor an adequate Hindi vocabulary. In journalistic Hindi, he renders *tilā-sakarānti* as *Makar Sankranti* in the very first line of *Gulo*! Do mainstream Brahminist and neo-Brahminist Maithili writers not themselves use the term *Makar Sankranti*? And could Subhash Chandra Yadav not have written *Makar Sankranti* in that first line instead of *tilā-sakarānti* if he had wanted to?

Therefore, if you wish to read Subhash Chandra Yadav's *Gulo* in both Hindi and Maithili, and to observe an application of the theory of gaslighting, read the Hindi translation first and the original Maithili afterwards. For the original Maithili will give you the experience of watching a film in a PVR cinema. Once you have read the original first, you will not be able to read even one page of the Hindi translation. And how, then, would you observe the operation of gaslighting? I want you to see that experiment.

In this context, it is necessary to discuss the 2021 Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili, given for the first time to a writer from a non-upper-caste background. Jagdish Prasad Mandal's novel *Pangu* begins where Yatri's *Balchanma* ends. People in the mainstream began to writhe in discomfort:

how had Jagdish Prasad Mandal moved beyond Yatri, while they themselves, far from moving beyond Yatri, were falling behind him? The novel was published electronically in nine instalments in *Videha* in 2018 and collected in *Videha: Sadeha*, volume 21 (pp. 677–779). It also appeared in book form that same year and is now available in the Videha repository. Rameshwar Prasad Mandal translated the book into Hindi for Pallavi Prakashan. I ask you to read that Hindi translation after reading the Maithili original: you will be able to finish the entire book. Both the Maithili *Pangu* and its Hindi translation are available in the Videha repository.

Let us return to the Hindi translation of *Gulo*. The table below shows how this translation was made and how an insider's view in Maithili was transformed, in its Hindi version, into an outsider's view through the translated-story-science of neo-Brahminism. In many places, because of a shortage of words in the translator's Hindi lexicon, a description is supplied in place of a corresponding word; often even that description is inaccurate. Elsewhere words are not translated at all, or literal translation and translation by sense turn the meaning into its opposite.

Original Maithili, Gulo	Published Hindi translation, Gulo
तिला-सकरांति	मकर संक्रान्ति
एक्के ससपेन मे मुँह तोड़ि	एक ही सस्पेन से मुँह तोड़
ओकरा टांसलकै	उसका घी बनाया
घरनियो*	पत्नी भी
टुकदुम-टुकदुम	किसी तरह
कबइ	कबई मछली
दबिया	दाब
देखबहक छौड़िए!	देखेगी तू,
देलियह	आपको दिए
अमाठी	आम की टहनियाँ
करची	बाँस की छड़ियाँ
कठुआयल	स्तंभित
दाब-दाब करैत रहै छै	दबाव बनाए रखते हैं
बात उनटा दइ छै**	बात को पलट देती है
पनिजाब	पंजाब
मुँह बाबि कऽ	हताश
सड़लाह खुट्टा	घुन लगे खूँटे
उपरेलक	ढूढ़कर लाई

Original Maithili, Gulo	Published Hindi translation, Gulo
गज्जन	इज्जत
ओगरइ-ए	देखभाल करता है
रमराहड़ि	अरहर
ठिठुआ***	ठिठुआ
कोय लटेलक	कोई उसे हथेली पर रगड़ता है
भाकन	जलकुम्भी
परचारै छै	ताना देती है
भोटिया	सुजनी
भोमहैर लेतै	काट खाएँगे
हपकुनियाँ	उंकडूं
चास,समार आ चौकी***	चास,समार और चौकी
टोन करइ-ए	टुकड़े-टुकड़े करती है
पांगय लागल	काटने लगा
खराय	डंठल सूखकर सख्त
गोसांइ डुमानी	सूर्य डूबने
पछड़ैत-पुछड़ैत	किसी तरह
सिदहा	भोजन की सामग्री
गुलो उकटि देलकै	गुलो ने कहा
जुमा कए	निशाना साधकर
हपसि-हपसि	हाँफ -हाँफ
भासि गेल	हिल गए
पाढ़ि	छप्पर को टेकनेवाला आधार
हटहट	पत्थर
गिरहत दहित रहै	गृहस्थ उदार था
छीलि-मोठि	छीलकर
हड़ौथ	हड़ौथ बाँस
खढ़ उछाहि देलकै	फूस उड़ गई
कालीबंदीक सेवा	कालीबंदी की पूजा
कुशक कलेप***	कुश का कलेप
पाट	अंतर्धान
आरा	बगीचा
गाछी	आम के बगीचे
गैढ़	काटकर

Original Maithili, Gulo	Published Hindi translation, Gulo
छौड़ी कए समांगे ने होइ छै	उसकी तबीयत ठीक नहीं है
टाट	घास फूस से बनी दीवार
दोसर बिछेलक	दूसरी बनाने लगा है
आलन	अस्तर
जैराठो	जड़ें
दू गो सुपारी नोत मे आयल छै	निमंत्रण की सुपारी मिली है
बाछ्य लागल	अलग करके रखने लगा
टिरसि कए	गुस्से में
कननमुँह	रुआँसा
बीट लगाएत	बाँस रोपेगा
सिसोहि लेलकै	तोड़ ले गया
अरिकंचन***	अरिकंचन
लाट मे झुनियो रहै	झुनिया भी थी
अढ़े-अढ़	चुपके से
नौ बजे राति मे	दस बजे रात में
ओलैत	चुनता
झखइ	अफसोस जता रहा
डंगेलक	उसे तैयार किया
टपय	आने
जोगतै	रखवाली कौन करेगा
सात-आठ टा नभका खुट्टा काटि	खूँटे काट रखे
खिखिर	नेवला
पजोठने	लेकर
हाक दाए	बुलाकर
जुआयल***	जुआया हुआ
गलि कए भात भाए जेतौ****	गलकर भात हो जाएगा
तुम्मा***	तुम्मा
अवाच कथा	बुरी बात
भूमकम	भूकम्प*****
भूकम्प	भूकम्प*****
ठठरी***	ठठरी
ऊक	मुखाग्नि
हिन्नू	हिन्दू

Original Maithili, Gulo	Published Hindi translation, Gulo
करइ छै, केना	बोलता क्या है
अरबा-अरबाइन***	अरबा-अरबाइन
झोड़ा	बटुआ
टानि कए	लेकर
अखरा***	अखरा

*Subhash Chandra Yadav uses *gharni* for 'wife', while Jagdish Prasad Mandal uses *bhansiya*. These are two distinct usages in two different situations. Would a translator render both simply as 'wife'?

**Reversing what someone says means twisting the statement; here it means giving the opposite answer straight away.

***Not translated.

****Literal translation.

*****Translation by sense.

Even the changes of chapter are not discernible in the Hindi version. In the original Maithili, each new section of the account begins on a new page, and photographs are placed where there is otherwise blank space, making the divisions clear.

Denmark has an extensive dictionary, extending, I believe, to more than twenty-three volumes. Immigrants often fail the Danish-language test required for citizenship. A woman who had married a Dane told me that her children had become Danish citizens but that the language examination was extremely difficult: even Danes, she said, sometimes failed it. A small population or geographical area has not impoverished Danish vocabulary.

Hindi has not expanded its vocabulary in proportion to the geographical territory it has acquired. In the United States, lists of 350 high-frequency English words and 3,500 basic words are available for high-school students; these lists approximately double in size as students proceed to college and graduate school (where what we call postgraduate study is called graduate school), even for students outside language departments. Students of literature and literary authors are expected to command ten times that vocabulary. In Hindi, except for the writers whom the custodians of Hindi dismiss or belittle as 'regional' novelists or authors, poets and novelists compose literature—poetry as well as novels—with the 2,000-word vocabulary of an eighth-grade student. Some Maithili writers wish to restrict themselves to that same basic 2,000-word list, whereas the signs of the Japanese writing systems alone number as many as five hundred.

In a language into which Ramlochan Sharan translated the fourteen to fifteen thousand lines of the *Shri Ramcharitmanas* in 1968 (Vikram Samvat 2025), preserving its full import in Maithili, a Hindi translation of *Gulo* of this kind, made in 2021 (Vikram Samvat 2078), is deeply disheartening.

The Preface to Gulo: 'The Saga of the Last Destitute Human Being' — by Kedar Kanan

Before the original Maithili *Gulo* begins, there is a preface entitled 'The Saga of the Last Destitute Human Being'. This is the mainstream's wailing, and on this occasion the burden of that wailing rests on Kedar Kanan's shoulders. Moreover, the preface was written on the day of *Tilā-Sankranti*!

But Subhash Chandra Yadav has not written the saga of the last destitute human being at all. This preface is a malicious attempt to place Yadav's writing on the other side of a divide. What he has written is the life story of Gulo Mandal—Gulo Mandal, who says:

> 'Do you recognise me? If you don't, get to know me. I am Gulo Mandal. My home is right here at this crossroads. If you try any high-handed tricks with me, you had better know who I am. I am Gulo Mandal.'

And it is Kedar Kanan who is behaving high-handedly towards Gulo Mandal.

> 'Those who put on large, conspicuous forehead marks regard it as a corruption of the language,' writes Kedar Kanan.

Yet Kedar Kanan does not have the courage to name those wearers of the conspicuous forehead marks.

Kedar Kanan has enjoyed every benefit bestowed by the forehead-marked people of the Sahitya Akademi and the Maithili Academy. Now that these people are on their deathbeds—and some have indeed died—he wants to make himself appear separate from them.

If the children of those forehead-marked patrons call Kedar Kanan, Veena Thakur, Ashok Avichal, and the others who have received translation and editing assignments worth lakhs of rupees, as well as Sahitya Akademi awards for children's literature or translation, ungrateful, that is a matter between those parties. But it remains true that they obtained those benefits through the favour of the children's forebears.

Furthermore, Kedar Kanan's preface teaches us that, if you do not wear such a forehead mark, or if you wear trousers and a shirt instead of a dhoti

and kurta, or if you are a neo-Brahminist, then you automatically acquire the right to practise every kind of deception and intrigue.

Gulo was published in 2015 with Kedar Kanan's preface.

Kedar Kanan received the 2019 Sahitya Akademi Translation Award for his Maithili translation of Kedarnath Singh's Hindi poetry collection *Akal Mein Saras* (*Cranes in a Drought*). Now first tell me: who is unable to read a Hindi poetry collection and therefore needs it in Maithili translation? Here Kedar Kanan benefited twice: a translation assignment and an award. Is that not so? For in *Ramta Jogi* (2019) Kedar Kanan is nowhere to be seen, and *Madar* (2021) has no preface at all.

Yet on the back cover of *Bhot* (2022), Kedar Kanan wrote eight lines—not one of them revolutionary. Why?

Now consider what the Sahitya Akademi did with the novel *Gulo*.

Works published between 2016 and 2020 were to be considered for the 2022 Sahitya Akademi Award. That meant that *Gulo* was out of the race.

In other words, the author of *Gulo*'s revolutionary preface received a Sahitya Akademi Translation Award, while *Gulo* itself was excluded from contention.

Was the preface to *Gulo*, then, an act of blackmail? That is certainly how it seems.

There is a great deal more wailing in the preface to *Gulo*.

'*Desil bayana sab jan mittha*'—'Everyone finds speech in the vernacular sweet'—is memorised by everyone in the mainstream, and Kedar Kanan knows it by heart too. But Avahattha was itself a literary language.

The Vidyapati who lived before Jyotirishwara was, however, distinct from Vidyapati Thakkurah, the Sanskrit and Avahattha poet. He may have been the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur, of the barber caste, from the village of Bisfi. In the *Bidapat Nach* of the parallel tradition, songs from the Vidyapati *Padavali* were enacted through dance and performance even before Jyotirishwara. There is evidence concerning this earlier Vidyapati in *Ishvara-Pratyabhijna-Vimarshini*, composed by Abhinavagupta of Kashmir in the late tenth or early eleventh century, where Vidyapati is mentioned. In Shridhar Das's *Saduktikarnamrita* (composed on 11 February 1206; see Vijay Kumar Thakur, *Medieval Mithila*), Shridhar Das quotes five verses by Vidyapati, in the language of Vidyapati's *Padavali*: 'Jav na malato kar paragas, tave na tahi madhukar vilas' and 'Mundala mukul katay makarand'. Jyotirishwara (1275–1350), in the Sixth Kallola, 'Description of the Learned', and the Eighth Kallola, 'Description of the Kingdom', mentions Bidapat. Vidyapati had become so famous that

Jyotirishwara referred to him in connection with the dance tradition. (Portrait of Vidyapati by Pankalal Mandal, recipient of the Videha Painting Award.)

> Kedar Kanan then provides a synopsis of the novel *Gulo*. It appears that he either did not read the novel carefully or failed to understand it. He writes: 'Anwar knows that the old woman [Sukhba's mother] has money. None of his efforts will be wasted ... he will squeeze it out of her,' and so on.

But nothing of the sort happens in the novel. Neither Anwar nor any other character behaves as Kedar Kanan wants to suggest. The owner of the plywood mill gives money when everyone believes he will refuse. The man responsible for the fan replaces it when even Gulo fears he will not. Anwar has helped on several occasions, and later even warns that vultures are circling in search of money. Yes, when payment was not forthcoming—or was delayed—he was once reluctant to help.

Kedar Kanan is astonished by the language of *Gulo*. The mainstream ought to be astonished by it. But his astonishment merely shows that he has been out of touch with Maithili literature for fifteen years.

> Many other things surprise him. Describing a situation after a quarrel in the novel, he writes that 'in so-called respectable society even an incident this small would cause an enormous upheaval, whereas in the homes of ordinary people such incidents occur all the time ...'.

Kedar Kanan's pretence of surprise is comical; I regard it as an expression of the mainstream's arrogance. It is as though he had come from another planet and lived in a vast mansion in Supaul, cut off from the world and its people.

This nine-page preface obstructs the reading of *Gulo*. I therefore urge you to begin the novel directly on page 17 and read it in a single sitting. Afterwards, return to this preface and read it as a piece of comic writing—or as a lament. In the Hindi translation of *Gulo*, Kedar Kanan's preface, 'The Saga of the Last Destitute Human Being', has been placed at the end of the novel. Gaurinath deserves thanks for that decision.

Gulo (Original Maithili)

In *Gulo*, the landlord and the owner of the orchard are mentioned only in passing. At one point, the owner is addressed as *babhna* ('Brahmin'), which indicates that he is a Brahmin.

Only after Gulo's death does Dr Malik arrive, weeping and asking who will now call him *malik* ('master'). One may assume he is a Kayastha, but the

novel gives no account of his caste. Thus there are a few passing mentions of a landlord or master and just one appearance by the doctor.

The wealthiest of all is Dashrath Mandal, the owner of the plywood mill.

Broadly speaking, the novel is divided into fourteen sections. Through flashback, it recounts Gulo Mandal's life and describes the environment around him. Its purpose is not an exhaustive account of time and place; it therefore does not analyse the underlying problems of society or the economy. Everything revolves around Gulo Mandal. Wherever Gulo's gaze falls, wherever his actual or imagined presence moves, the novel travels too. It may wander elsewhere for a little while, but it returns to him. Even after his death, when people are making arrangements to claim their shares of the relief money, the writer returns to Riniya. She hears Gulo calling and strains her ears in the hope of hearing her father call once more: 'She kept listening.' The novel ends: 'Baba has gone away. Riniya weeps.'

Unlike an ordinary novel, this book calls for analysis in terms of the textuality of words and sentences: Julia Kristeva's horizontal axis of relations connecting author and reader, and the vertical axis connecting this text with other texts.

Gulo is not divided into chapters. It flows like a continuous stream, although the printed version uses typography to provide chapters or sections for the reader's convenience. In a number of places, paragraph spacing also marks subdivisions within a section.

Let us now read *Gulo* once more.

The First Section of Gulo

The text begins with *Tila Sankranti*, not *Makar Sankranti*! (This is a point for the translator.)

Riniya (Gulo's youngest daughter) is plastering the courtyard with a fresh coating of earth, singing as she works. Do you detect any wailing or sense of inferiority in Gulo's family? Experience the scene cinematographically; reflect upon it: the plastering accompanied by song, then dew like a fine spray of water, the westerly wind, the bitter cold, Riniya wearing only a salwar and a frock, and her mother's cry: “This girl will not let me live! Girl, why don't you wrap yourself in a shawl?” Now stage this scene. But a shawl would drag and become smeared with mud while she was plastering the courtyard; that would happen after she had soiled it. (This is a point for the translator.)

Now imagine that this is not the home of Gulo Mandal but of Gulo Kanan, a member of so-called respectable society.

Morning arrives in much the same way in so-called respectable society; people say *Tila Sankranti* in the same way, plaster the courtyard in the same way, and a mother shouts in the same way: "This girl will not let me live! Girl, why don't you wrap yourself in a shawl?"

You will find the other details of morning in Gulo's household here as well.

The Second Section of Gulo

A flashback within a single paragraph: Gulo's father, Munilal; Gulo's two younger sisters; the death of their mother; and their father's departure from his railway job. Banerjee Sahib, the senior railway clerk at Saharsa, did not want Munilal to leave: who would bring him those enormous live *kabai* fish? After bearing three children, Munilal's eldest daughter was widowed. Munilal brought everyone to live with him. His grandson Mahendar was nimble and cunning; he got the ancestral homestead registered in his own name. Gulo fled to Kosi Chowk in Supaul and settled on Bihar government land.

While employed by the railways, Munilal had made numerous implements out of iron and other metal: small and large hoes, spades, digging bars, billhooks, axes, spears and lances. All these are still in Gulo's house. That is his paternal inheritance. His forebears have left him nothing else.

Then comes Riniya's liveliness. She received five hundred rupees from school as a uniform allowance. Her teacher had told her, "Buy yourself shoes." But the money was spent on another of Gulo's pressing needs. Riniya complains: "You gobbled up the lot!"

The Third Section of Gulo

The clash between Chhotua (Gulo's younger son) and Riniya over their attitudes towards work.

The Fourth Section of Gulo

A month earlier Gulo's eldest son Arjunma had left for *Panijab* (not *Punjab*—a note for the translator). Kandahawali (Arjunma's wife) and Sujit (Arjunma's son).

Riniya's stomach is churning, which is why she keeps spitting.

Fish had been cooked on New Year's Day, because New Year's Day has now become a festival for everyone. That day Riniya had thrown up the fish, although she had been asking to eat meat.

Next to Gulo's house, Anwar sits in a small wooden enclosure. He gives injections and charges ten rupees for each one.

Gulo's in-laws live in Bela, and his wife's name is Belawali.

Earlier, Gulo's asthma had flared up while he was smoking cannabis. That suggests that the trade in cannabis intoxication must be widespread there. From Bela, his wife's brother's wife has come to see her sister-in-law—that is, Gulo's wife—and says, "This ganja-smoker has killed my sister."

Kandahawali managed to procure firewood (*uparēlak*: arranged for it; she did not simply "bring it"—a note for the translator).

There is the obligation to honour an invitation to a nephew's wedding: they must give a sari, a petticoat, a blouse and two hundred and fifty-one rupees. Gulo travels to Sonak with Chhotua and Riniya. His eldest daughter Runiya has also arrived there directly from her marital home. She wants to take her sister Riniya back with her, but Riniya refuses: people would say that her father had become ill and the family had fallen on hard times, so she had gone to her sister's house to be fed. She cries bitterly. Gulo is astonished: how has this girl come to understand all these things? His daughter-in-law is restrained; but if she had refused, no duty would have remained unperformed (this is not simply a question of "honour"; that word is too small—a note for the translator). "I would even have taken a beating…"

For Riniya, Sonak is no less than a pilgrimage site: she has never even seen a train, let alone ridden in one. She has only heard of it. There are, then, two Indias.

The Fifth Section of Gulo

The smoke of the warming fire. "Anwar gives no reply. He has helped several times before—given money, medicines, injections. … Gulo shows no sign of going back."

The Sixth Section of Gulo

Rajindar the ration dealer and his co-in-law Inra Ganhi. Inra Ganhi's eldest son, Doma, runs a grocery store. His second son runs a betel shop, keeps chargers of all kinds, and takes five rupees to charge a mobile phone. There is hardly any electricity in Punarbās. His third son recharges mobile phones, downloads films and songs, makes photocopies and takes photographs. His fourth son, Barjesh, has a medicine shop. He says, "The only difference between a doctor and me is that the doctor has a degree and I don't."

The Seventh Section of Gulo

Kandahawali finds a new livelihood harvesting *makhana* at the Malhad depression.

Sukhba turned his mother out of the house. She is the wife of Inra Ganhi's paternal uncle-in-law.

Sukhba brought his mother back home.

The Eighth Section of Gulo

Mung beans must be sown. The ploughman asks for two hundred and fifty rupees for ploughing, levelling and giving the field its final smoothing.

The irrigation pump needs to be repaired.

"It's the parliamentary election. Congress has fielded Ranjita Ranjan." Nareshba is supposed to get a thousand rupees from Ranjita Ranjan for Gulo; there are six votes in Gulo's family. But Nareshba vanishes. Phulba, meanwhile, will make Modi win, though Gulo refuses to attend the meeting: "You (Phulba) must have got a hefty bundle of notes. You go and hold your meeting!"

Then another quarrel at home: Kandahawali makes a noose from her sari and puts it around her neck. She locks up the seed wheat in a drum and leaves for her parental home.

The Ninth Section of Gulo

Two of Gulo's houses have been swept away.

The holy man tells him that a curse has been scattered over the house. He gives him an amulet, but it proves useless.

Service to Kalibandi, the *bhagat* and Phulhasi. Now even the ritual coating of *kush* grass will not be applied.

The Tenth Section of Gulo

Chhotua works for Dashrath Mandal, the owner of a brick kiln. He asks for a twelve-hundred-rupee advance to repair the irrigation pump but receives a thousand. Instead of repairing the pump, however, he buys a bicycle, because Arjunma had sold the bicycle he had bought with his own earnings. Chhotua wants to prove something to him.

Anwar gives Riniya tablets to bring down her fever.

The Tenth Section of Gulo

Gulo has received two *suparis*, ceremonial betel nuts accompanying two wedding invitations: one for Lalo Pandit's granddaughter's wedding and the other for the wedding of his wife's sister's daughter at Jaidhi.

The Eleventh Section of Gulo

Gulo will ask the landowner for a torch. If he does not give him one, Gulo will not allow him to enjoy a single mango or *luchchi* fruit.

Bamboo costs no less than a hundred and fifty rupees a pole. Since Gulo has stolen the bamboo to sell, he must let it go for just a hundred. He gets five hundred rupees for five poles; with the money Riniya buys a young she-goat. Within an hour the kid recognises Riniya.

The landowner does not give him a torch, so he buys one, spending fifty rupees of his own.

The thief strips all the *luchchi* fruit from the trees. One Thakur man is an accomplished thief.

Riniya, Jhuniya and Barsserwali steal *luchchi* fruit.

"Didn't he catch you?" Riniya asks.

"That Brahmin, catch me? ..." (Barsserwali.)

Gulo's eldest daughter Runiya is married in Bina. She calls on Anwar's mobile phone. Gulo goes there, and Chhotua accompanies him. The *luchchi* fruit Riniya has gathered becomes a gift to be taken along.

Riniya gives the first picking of mung beans to Satalrenma, who pays her twenty rupees.

Runiya's brother-in-law Nerhu arrives. He keeps looking silently at Riniya and smiling.

The son of Dashrath Mandal's wife's sister's husband lives in Nepal; a marriage proposal comes for Riniya. But Gulo asks for four months' time. Arjunma is worthless, yet Gulo will consult him nevertheless.

The Twelfth Section of Gulo

Arjunma calls Anwar's mobile phone and lets loose a stream of abuse.

Gulo is coughing. There is talk of uprooting *thokara* from two *katthas* of land for two hundred rupees. How much dust must have entered his lungs! He digs and clears the growth. A ten-rupee fan breaks, but Nangra replaces it with another.

The Thirteenth Section of Gulo

Once, when Riniya brought tree-ripened mangoes, the landowner gave her fifty rupees. The mistress of the house gave her some to eat as well.

Belawali's fever simply will not subside. Which boy, which woman took how many mangoes?

Gulo spends the entire night tossing and turning. He is breathless and coughing.

"The old woman has a fever. He (Gulo) can scarcely get up himself. ... The girl runs alone, now to the house, now to the orchard. The boy sleeps until eight in the morning."

The Final Section of Gulo

Gulo has cut and set aside seven or eight new posts. ... Now it hardly seems possible that he can do anything at all.

Riniya's young goat will neither eat nor drink. Who knows what has happened to it?

In other years Gulo used to guard the orchard even at night. This year he cannot. He no longer has that much strength.

...Kandahawali arrives. "Papa, call the pump mechanic. He'll put it right."

Gulo says, "Daughter-in-law, that'll cost a thousand rupees. I haven't a single rupee in hand."

"Just call him. We'll pay whatever it costs."

Arjun returns from Panijab.

His nephew Mahindar, who had dishonestly got Gulo's homestead transferred to his name by Gulo's father—that cheating nephew hears his maternal uncle is ill and comes to visit. Gulo tells him an unutterable tale of suffering.

Mahindar arranges worship of Satlarayan Bhagwan. Riniya goes there, and her sister-in-law asks her to remain for the night. Riniya learns that Gulo is in very poor spirits. She comes home early in the morning.

The novel's tremendous ending ... Look at the artistry.

Her mother asks her about the previous night's worship. Riniya has no wish to listen to the news of what happened there. She says to her mother, "Ma, give me some money. I'll go and get Papa's medicine."

...

Riniya grasps him by the shoulder and shakes him: "Papa!"

Nothing. Nothing anywhere.

"Ma, run! Come and see what's happened to Papa! Papa! Oh, Papa! Papa, oh, Papa!"

...

"The soul-bird has flown away."

Then, because there is no money, there is no firewood; and without firewood, Gulo will have to be buried.

"...There's an earthquake!" Parmesar cries.

...

The earthquake comes again.

Just as the funeral fire is being lit, two men, Kanhaiya and Jagdish, arrive on a motorcycle.

Now the dead Gulo is taken to hospital, where a post-mortem is performed. The rumour that Gulo died in the earthquake had already been circulating at the hospital, and the paperwork is made to say so.

Gulo is brought back to the cremation ground for a second time. Chhotua lights the fire; then the two of them cover Gulo with earth, shovelling it over him.

Some Muslim men and women who watch the fire being lit and the body also being buried ask, "Is he a Hindu or a Muslim? ... Do Hindus have a religion at all? ... What use is religion? If there's money, the children can at least get by. ..."

After the earthquake, politicians and ministers compete to announce relief payments. The writer wants to show here how, whenever a natural disaster occurs, politicians vie to give compensation for the dead—and to remain in the news while doing so.

Ward commissioner: one thousand five hundred rupees ...

Member of Parliament: five thousand rupees ...

Minister: ten thousand rupees ...

Government official: a cheque for four lakh rupees ...

And then the wrangling over that money ...

Jagdish wants one lakh of it for himself. But the writer turns back to Riniya.

"Riniya is sad. She remembers Papa. ... Oh, Ma! What a clear voice he had. ... She feels like calling out: Papa! Oh, Papa! ..."

Ramta Jogi

A travel account in diary form. The author writes [5 March 2019]: "Most of the travel literature written in Maithili so far is dull and lifeless. It is a

storehouse of unnecessary descriptions and insignificant information. There is more chronicle than narrative in it. This diary-style account does not offer a minute, detailed investigation of history and archaeology. Instead, it contains engaging human episodes that illuminate the lifestyles and cultures of different countries."

The author is impressed by Australia: "Australia is a developed, prosperous, clean country with pure air and an advanced standard of living. ... Because poverty, illiteracy and social discrimination are absent, there is great peace in the life of its people."

I recall a friend of mine who went to Darbhanga for an examination, walked around the university area, returned, and declared that there was no city better than Darbhanga in all Bihar. The author does say that his travelogue lacks a fine-grained, detailed inquiry into history and archaeology. Yet, in the light of the preceding paragraph, I would draw attention to this: when Britain lost its American colony in 1778, it no longer had Virginia to which it could send convicts. Captain Phillip therefore set out with livestock, seeds, sheep and ploughs in three ships, together with six smaller vessels and 1,400 men and women, half of them convicts, and reached the coast of what is now Sydney on 26 January 1788. The original Aboriginal inhabitants of Australia were gradually pushed away from the coastal regions on every side towards the interior wastelands. Their waterholes were seized. Even today, when Australia Day is celebrated there on 26 January, the original inhabitants observe it as a day of mourning; they now live on reservations (designated forest areas). James Cook, by contrast, treated the Māori inhabitants well when he went to New Zealand.

Let us now turn to *Ramta Jogi*.

[30 September 2018] He leaves for Melbourne in business class with his son Kumar Saumya.

On arrival he sends a photograph to his elder son, Santosh Kumar. Kumar Saumya is a chartered accountant, and his daughter-in-law Madhulika (Madhu) is a software engineer. To indicate that his son married within his own caste, the author uses the following sentence: "A curry of *bhata* and *adauri* has been prepared. The *adauri* came from Madhulika's mother, Jaymala Yadav ..."

There is mention of some Indian-owned shops at Sanctuary Lakes, and of Patanjali products. For four months Saumya cared for his mother, who was suffering from cancer, until her death; now he has brought his father with him. Saumya says that what they call an orange here is called a mandarin in Australia. Point Cook lies in the western part of Melbourne. Many

Indians and Africans live here, and crime occurs here too. (The author does not explain *why* it occurs.)

Swastika Goenka (a chartered accountant) and Anand Goenka (a software engineer) are mentioned. The Hindi film *Sui Dhaaga* is showing in Australia. At Dosa Hut all the waitresses are beautiful Indian young women. One of them smiled for rather a long time. The author wonders why she smiled. Be that as it may, in a life grown dry, such a fluid experience of spiritual intimacy brings pleasure for a few moments.

Good news arrives from India: the university has become ready to pay his pension arrears. Long-distance trains here are called B-line trains; even these do not meet with accidents. Trams run in the city. It is not only Calcutta that has trams, and the trams here are better.

He speaks with Rahul Vats, Kedar Kanan's nephew. Rahul and his wife Ashwini are both engineers employed in Melbourne; they have a daughter, Ayska. He also speaks with Ahmed Nomani of Kishanpur.

He hears two *Habshi* men and a woman shouting. "Negro" and "Habshi" are derogatory words, just as calling the Gidarmara people of Simra in Madhubani "Banjara" is derogatory; in Pakistan, "Pathan" is used to insult Pashtuns, although in India people also use Pathan as a surname. Later, however, the author himself distances himself from the use of "Habshi."

The relationship between father-in-law and daughter-in-law—not mother-in-law and daughter-in-law—is clarified. "Many parents, when visiting their children, buy that country's currency in advance. Had you done the same, I would have felt very bad. Madhu is somewhat outspoken."

Durga Puja in Melbourne's Rockbank. "Violence has no place here." Four years earlier he had gone with Kedar Kanan, Sushmita, Tussi and Raman Kumar Singh to see Taranand Viyogi at Mahishi on Maha Ashtami. They visited Mother Tara and witnessed a sacrifice, then went to the shrine of Karu, where people offer milk. Viyogi said: "Blood flows at Tara's shrine, and milk flows at Karu's shrine!"

Most of the car drivers are women.

"An office drinking party; Madhu was hung over."

Saumya wants to settle in Australia. He has been there for three years; once he completes four years, he will apply for citizenship.

"Two women walked down the street close together, wrapped in the same shawl. Quite possibly they were lesbians."

Shashi Kapoor had said of his experiences abroad that when his friends touched one another and joked around, people there thought they were gay. The author must therefore have made a fair guess.

Saumya wants to settle there, but Madhu is afraid.

The author speaks with Professor Mahendra Jha; his pension for June and July has arrived. Mahendra wants him to write a great deal of literature while there, as do Kedar, Kamta, Vinay Kumar Jha and Vaidyanath Jha. The first part of the novel *Madar* appeared in *Antika* in March 2016, but nothing appeared after that. On 24 October 2018 he began writing a new novel, though he has not yet thought of a title. Sachchidanand Sachchu liked the extract from *Madar* very much and sent him a message.

The paddy on the author's land at Punarbas in Supaul will be harvested; he has given the land out on a crop-sharing arrangement. It still has to be threshed. If the sharecropper again makes some excuse, the matter will drag on for months. He is speaking with two people, but worries that they will squeeze money out of him and cheat him.

Madhu orders three glasses of white wine (described as country liquor). It tastes rather like *tari*, palm sap liquor.

Saumya orders sushi, a Japanese dish (described here as made from leftover rice and chicken).

There is barramundi, a sea fish, but it does not taste like fish from ponds, *chaaps*, or flowing channels. Raman Kumar Singh has won some award for his poetry collection *Ferasan Hariyar* (the award is not named). He is translating *Gulo* into Hindi (28 October 2018).

29 October 2018: He writes four pages. If he writes even this much every day, the novel will be ready in a month. (The Japanese novelist Haruki Murakami writes ten Japanese pages without fail each day—roughly 1,600 words.)

The municipal council here is called Wyndham. An African greeting: two fists are bumped together. With a Myki card you can travel on the metro, bus and tram. One station has the curious name Aircraft.

A woman begging for money boards the carriage. Saumya thinks she may be begging to buy drugs. Later they see her downstairs, approaching with a cigarette between her lips. She rubs her chest as though looking for a lighter—or perhaps it is a sexual gesture.

To keep his haemoglobin at a normal level, the author has to take an Enfo injection once a month.

There is an invitation today. Vikas, Priyanka, Abhishek, Nidhi and Ashwini are there. Vikas's and Ashwini's jobs are in jeopardy. Nidhi's mother calls from Tata.

At a barber's shop, a woman is busy keeping the shop's accounts. "She looked up. She realised that I had been looking at her already. … She looked at me. I looked at her. I became frightened. What happened to her?"

If you call Africans "Habshi" or "black," they will be offended. All Africans, the account says, are dark and tall; very few have an attractive physique. It was sheer coincidence that the young African woman present in the restaurant was beautiful.

Saumya's friend Jaswant Singh has married Angelina, a Christian. There is no question of religious conversion: there will be a *yajna* as well as prayers in church.

Saumya and Madhu both take part in snorkelling and scuba diving. They see the reef; the bottom of the boat has a glass panel.

Jess Tia and Becky Baldock embrace one another. Jess Tia takes the initiative. There is a magnetic current in Becky's embrace.

At the Frogs restaurant one can eat crocodile meat. One can buy kangaroo skin and hear an Aboriginal Australian playing the ancient didgeridoo.

Here you have to fill the petrol tank yourself.

"Today, for the first time, I am eating pork (pig meat)."

Penguin Parade …

"In the morning I saw Kedar's message. The District Magistrate wanted to speak with me. … He was merely curious how I was doing in Melbourne. I too felt reassured."

"I saw two young women holding each other tightly and kissing. They seemed to be lesbians. Homosexuality is legal in Australia. Gay men can marry gay men, and lesbians can marry lesbians."

Ankur comes to visit. He had studied with Madhu.

Two women board the railway carriage. Madhu says they are revellers; they take intoxicating injections and spend their time in revelry.

A round, shaggy koala, about two handspans long, squats on a branch: an indolent creature.

Kangaroo … *sahmilu*.

The emu, white pelican, lyrebird and Tasmanian devil (endangered).

From Australia to Kuala Lumpur, and then to Ho Chi Minh City. In this city of ten million people there are seven million two-wheelers.

Southern Vietnam and the Mekong River. "For the first time I saw paddy harvested by machine." Snakes and chickens are eaten in Vietnam. There is a belief there that eating dog meat increases virility.

"In Vietnam I miss Mahaprakash very much."

A city tour and a Chinese pagoda. Those who have no children buy birds and release them. Madhu buys a bird and releases it.

From Ho Chi Minh City to Hanoi in northern Vietnam. The river there is the Red River.

They meet Madhu's friend Ruchi and her husband Gaurav there.

The notebook containing the travel account is lost and then found again.

Ruchi is a Brahmin and the daughter of an IAS officer; Gaurav is a Rajput. They married for love. Ruchi's father strongly opposed the marriage.

A puppet sometimes takes the form of a dolphin and sometimes that of a fish.

There is an embrace of farewell with Ruchi.

Angkor Wat in Cambodia represents a synthesis of Hinduism and Buddhism. Brother Yogendra Pathak Viyogi has made a very fine and detailed investigation of Angkor Wat.

At the crossroads of Pub Street, a man of about thirty-five: "Want girl, sir? Thirty dollars for one hour. Sixty dollars for one night." "No, I don't want." A Spanish woman: "Unos, dos, tres ..." (One, two, three.)

"I asked, '¿Dónde vive usted?' (Where do you live?)"

"She said, 'España' (Spain)."

"... At night I taste liquid frog."

Bangkok, Suvarnabhumi Airport. In the centre stands a sculpture depicting the churning of the ocean. There is a warning in Hindi too: "No tips." Bangkok's tall Wat Arun temple.

Pattaya: an emaciated, worn-looking Buddha. "I had never seen an image of the Buddha like this. We shall reach Mumbai at one in the morning. Samrat will receive us." [4 January 2019]

Appendix: The Andaman Diary

September 2012: My middle son Sanjay, who is going to Port Blair with his wife, invites me along. I shall travel from Saharsa, they from Mumbai, and we shall meet at Port Blair Airport.

Annadurai is standing with a taxi. He is building a house in Chennai because he fears the Andamans may one day sink into the sea. His driver Uday, from Ranchi, arrives later. Port Blair even has a neighbourhood named Ranchi. Bengalis form the largest population in the Andamans, followed by Tamils.

North Bay: the mountain and forest shown on the twenty-rupee note belong to this island. There is snorkelling, scuba diving, speedboating and a coral reef. From a glass-bottomed boat, one can see the marine world while remaining seated.

Plastic is prohibited on Jolly Buoy Island.

Baratang and the Jarawa Indigenous people. My friend Lallan (Vinay Kumar Jha, IAS) had strongly insisted: "You must see the Jarawa."

Havelock Island.

Madar

Dedicated to the literature-loving Samrat and Neha, this book concerns relations between men and women and the way suspicion turns its male antihero, Madan, into a murderer. The novel ends with the possibility that a relative from a criminal background, who has given him refuge, may exploit Madan, and with Madan's psychological turmoil.

Madan's wife Radha supports the household through sewing and other small jobs. Her eldest daughter, Shanichari, was born on a Saturday. But she is nowhere to be found. The blouse for the woman from Gamharia has been stitched. If Shanichari delivered it, they would get twenty rupees and could buy rice and potatoes. Were Radha to go herself, Madan might see her and create a terrible scene. He does not let her go anywhere. The worm of suspicion keeps writhing in his head.

But it had not always been like this. Madan used to check whether Radha had run out of oil and soap. His father, Kamesar Azad, had passed the intermediate examination in his day. His father and uncle together had held fifty or sixty bighas of cultivated land. After his uncle's death, however, the family property was divided, and only five bighas fell to Kamesar, who had two sons and two daughters to support, as well as himself and his wife. Kamesar took a keen interest in community affairs and caring for the sick. His two sons somehow completed their BAs.

Madan fled to Bombay, but there he missed Radha. The work was very hard, so he returned; Radha had gone to her parental home. He went there, but she had gone to the cinema with the elder husband of one of her sisters. His suspicion began at that very point.

Kamesar brought Radha back from her parental home. Shanichari was born, and then Karmu. Madan's suspicion did not diminish. He began keeping watch on her and beating her.

The two brothers, Madan and Kishore, separated their households. A *shisham* tree beside the ridge in their field had dried up. Its price was agreed upon, but Kishore raised an objection and the buyer withdrew. Eventually it was sold.

Madan fought with Kamla, bit off her ear, and fled. Kamla filed a case; Kamesar paid the police two or three hundred rupees to quieten matters. Madan's *pisa* (his aunt's husband) arranged a tempo for him, and he began driving between Pipra and Supaul. Kamesar brought Radha home from her parents' house, but her mother warned her: "Keep him under control, or he will bring shame upon you." The beatings resumed, and Radha went back to her parental home at Tintolia. She was pregnant.

After matriculation Radha had enrolled in intermediate studies. The examination form now had to be filled in. Her friend had come from her marital home for that purpose. The college was at Raghopur. Radha filled out the form.

There had once been a time when Madan would strip her naked. "There is no greater pleasure in life than this." But it was not so now; now there was suffering. Radha thought of running away somewhere, of eloping with someone. Ashok … she saw affection for herself in his eyes. Then she remembered Shanichari and Karmu. What would become of the nursing child in her lap?

Radha remembered several young men who had cared for her. They would pick *ber* fruits or *jilebi* fruits, give her mangoes and jamuns, but had never pressed their bodies against hers. There was also her brother-in-law from Karjain, sweet-spoken as he was. Once, in winter, he had brought a very beautiful woollen cap from Nepal.

The intermediate results came out. Radha had secured a first division in the intermediate examination too (meaning that she had also obtained a first division in matriculation). In her marital village, Pathra, her house stood a little way from Mahavir's. Two girls from Pathra had taken the intermediate examination, but neither had obtained a first division. Mahavir had passed in the first division and would apply for a teaching job at the primary school of Pathra Panchayat. The *mukhiya* told him that

some money would have to be paid to the official: if it cost four or five thousand rupees, the honorarium would be fifteen hundred, so the expense could be recovered in three or four months. Mahavir had come to Tintolia to bring his sister back from her parents' home. He said that if Radha applied, she too could get a teaching post at the Pathra school. Her father-in-law had sent word as well. Radha herself wanted the job.

As soon as her intermediate examination ended, Radha gave birth to another daughter.

Radha obtained a job. Madan seemed now to have forgotten his abuse and beatings. Mahavir was employed at the same school. Rekha, Radha's sister, also came there; her marital home too was at Pathra.

But on the pretext of asking about her honorarium, Madan kept Radha under surveillance. There was a man named Raghunath Sahni, who went around declaring to everyone, "You can never trust a *Gorhni* woman!" Raghunath was simply mad; Madan was not. … He made Radha leave her job. She stayed at home. Madan went to his maternal relatives for help but received only five hundred rupees. The teachers' honorarium had meanwhile risen to four thousand rupees. Radha regretted her loss all the more. Mahavir suggested that she meet the headmaster and the *mukhiya* about being reinstated. The headmaster sent her to the *mukhiya*. Kamesar went to see him, but the *mukhiya* flatly refused: too much time had passed.

Madan suspects Radha whenever she meets Mahavir. Kamesar continues to take an interest in her situation, asking what has happened and what hardships she faces. Why, Madan asks, does she whisper with her father-in-law? Radha is distressed.

Madan visits his sister. His brother-in-law Rajkumar teaches at an intermediate college. He receives no salary, although private tutoring is going well. The brother-in-law asks him, "Why did you make your wife leave her job? You are suspicious for no reason."

Madan leaves. When he returns home, Radha has poured kerosene over herself and set herself on fire. Kamesar has cared for Radha so much—surely there must be something improper between them, Madan thinks.

Whenever Madan visited his sister, Radha would mutter, "He hasn't spared even the father-in-law and the elder brother-in-law. … I'll set myself on fire …"

"… Kamesar brings a young man with him. … He buys tonic for Radha. Why does his father worry so much about the two of them?" Madan keeps thinking. His suspicion hardens into certainty.

Radha says, "Please bring some rice from the elder sister at Piprahi."

The sister gives him five kilos of rice. Madan flies into a rage: "Keep your rice!"

"All of this is that woman's doing. She has lured the old man into sleeping beside her." Seeing the billhook in her father's hand, Shanichari is terrified: "Don't kill Ma, Papa!" … Radha's throat is cut.

Madan flees. At Rampur is the marital home of his maternal uncle. The middle brother of the uncle's wife is the leader of a gang of criminals. Madan goes to the elder brother of the uncle's wife; the elder brother's wife is frightened. The middle brother is also there and says, "I will keep him here." As Madan lies there, he dozes off. Radha appears again, dressed in white, a noose wrapped around her neck.

His sleep breaks. Radha is nowhere to be seen. Yet he feels that she is standing in front of him.

Bhot (The Vote)

In *Bhot*, Yaduvansh, the nephew of the author-protagonist or narrator (the relationship is disclosed only later), calls him. Yaduvansh had once been an MLA many years earlier (that fact, too, is related later), and people still address him as "MLA-ji." Since the protagonist, Subhash-ji, is regarded as a respectable man, Yaduvansh asks him for help. He reaches Kariho. RJD leader Rajinder tells him that the boat will be carried across if he merely drinks a cup of tea in everyone's home.

The RJD, JD(U), and Congress have formed an alliance for the assembly election. Yaduvansh Kumar Yadav is the candidate from the Pipra constituency, which has fallen to the RJD's share. Kariho formerly lay within Supaul; this time it has been cut off and put into Pipra. Bijendra Yadav used to win from here, so most voters in the area support the JD(U). Rajinder Yadav once contested a mukhiya election here. He failed to win, but he is an able man. His name is on the rolls of a nongovernment college. He goes there two or four days in a month, marks his attendance, and returns. Whenever a grant arrives there is a little income. Everyone moves around in a group, and the protagonist accompanies them. If a programme is arranged in Hardi, the protagonist will go with Kamta, a JD(U) man, though neither Dina Pathak, also of the JD(U), nor another Congress worker knows anything about it. The protagonist warns Kamta that thinking in this fashion will weaken the alliance between the RJD, JD(U), and Congress. Kamta agrees to go to Hardi and then return to Kariho via Harda. This is the protagonist's first experience of election campaigning. Yaduvansh says he has no money. That troubles the protagonist: how can he contest an election without funds? How much could the protagonist donate—five or ten thousand rupees? It would be

better to spend that amount on campaigning; even tea and refreshments cost a great deal. He thinks of taking responsibility for Kariho's expenses, but then wonders how large they might become. The protagonist and Kamta studied in Supaul, while Yaduvansh studied in Rafiganj. The protagonist tells a story about those days. He and Yaduvansh went to Ekdara on Kamta's bicycle, and the bicycle was stolen there. Kamta reminds Yaduvansh of it. Yaduvansh is now to become an MLA from Kamta's own area; they will need one another. Yet party loyalties have left a distance between them. Their senior leaders may have reached a compromise, but can so many years of bitterness disappear like steam at once?

Bindulal Das is a joker who tells anecdotes. The proprietor of a tea stall is known as BDO: he used to take bribes, was suspended, and now sells tea. Everyone laughs uproariously. This BDO has not even passed the intermediate examination. The protagonist asks the tea-seller whom he will vote for, but receives an oblique reply: "Why should I tell you whom I will or won't vote for?" The BJP candidate is Vishwamohan. He was an MP once, lost the next time, and his wife Sujata is now the local MLA. Vishwamohan is a Keot. Dilesar Kamat, also a Keot, had once won here. Dinbandhu Yadav, son-in-law of socialist leader Vinayak Yadav, also won once. Pipra has a large Keot population; the Dhanuks come second and the Yadavs third. The Dhanuks have no candidate of their own, so their votes will be divided. The Chaudharis are Banias, and the BJP is regarded as a Bania party; where will they go if they leave it? Of course, money can turn someone's head. Socialist Party candidate Satyanarayan Gupta is a Teli, and the greater part of the Teli vote will go to him. Hardly anyone speaks of the Left candidate, Nagesar Yadav. Muslims are alienated from the BJP and support the Grand Alliance. Brahmins, in contrast, are alienated from the alliance. Sukhdev belongs to the BJP, although the public is unhappy with its candidate.

Shivji owns a tea stall. He makes poor tea, is often intoxicated, and abuses everyone up to and including the prime minister. He urges the protagonist to meet expenses: "What do you lack?" Shivji's daughter Lachhmi wears jeans and a top. She has become adept at making litti and tea and attending to customers. Shivji asks the protagonist to test her schooling. He asks her what *pushpa* means. "Flower," she answers. "Shivji, your daughter is clever at her studies!" The protagonist has told everyone of his relationship with the candidate, and word spreads. He will return ten days later. His wife asks, "What will come of your running back and forth? Will people cast their votes just because you say so?" "They might. Fifty or a hundred votes could make a difference. Yaduvansh would benefit." "And what will Yaduvansh give you?" "If he does his work, there may be a little

money as well." "Will campaigning feed us? Not everything is money." "If I do nothing for him today, will he do anything for me tomorrow?" Exasperated, his wife says, "Do whatever you please."

Yaduvansh files his nomination. Prabhas is in charge. As the election approaches, the protagonist reaches Kariho. Kamta has gone to campaign for Minister-ji, the candidate of his own JD(U) party. The constituency has changed, but the party has not. Bindu works as a teacher, in a private school. "Fifty rupees a month. Some people pay, some do not. Whatever comes, I accept—rice, milk, even firewood." He was once elected a member of the panchayat samiti. By speaking to the mukhiya he arranged bits of public work, an Indira Awas house for someone, an old-age pension for someone else. After a job was done, people gave him ten or twenty rupees. But he lost the following election owing to caste mobilisation.

Mannu deals in livestock. "Just make some provision for the campaigning expenses." "Mannu doesn't seem to recognise my worth!" "Mannu-bhai, elections used to be so pleasant and peaceful. Now they're a scramble of self-interest."

Today the targets are Musahari and Domrahi. Kariho has two densely settled Musahar hamlets, with Domrahi close beside them. "Go to every voter's doorstep. They should be able to say: 'I too was given a handbill; I too was asked.'" They cover both hamlets of Kariho and the Musahari settlement of Bagahi. Evening falls. Chandesari takes tea-and-refreshment money from the protagonist, and another hundred rupees for a leader of the Musahari settlement. They set out carrying Nitish Kumar's appeal to voters, the manifesto of his Seven Resolves, sample ballot papers, and calendars. "Brother, you've brought bundles and bundles!" "Why am I getting myself into this mess?" "Explain it properly to the women. Tell them Nitish and Lalu have come together. They have become one. This time there will be no arrow symbol here; it will be the lantern. Even if you vote for the lantern this time, Nitish will win." A woman asks, "Nitish will become chief minister, won't he? He has done so much for women." Women are staunch supporters of Nitish.

"Safina has come!" announces Jamil. He relates how Safina can silence even the most formidable people, then tells another story about her. She once stood for mukhiya; people recognised her. Chandesari was devoted to Safina and greatly enjoyed going about with her. But whom would she vote for? Chandesari wonders: when will people vote on the basis of work? Safina is not highly educated; she has passed the *Fauqania* examination.

Vishwamohan's house is nearby. One can get five hundred rupees there. Sanjay and Jayprakash both support the BJP. Every day the newspapers

report bundles of currency notes and bottles of liquor being seized. Gagna says meat and liquor are being distributed: "The BJP has already won."

In Supaul, Rahul Gandhi has given a speech. Gandhi Maidan was full. He called Modi a thief, accused him of instigating riots and setting Hindus against Muslims, and said the alliance would win. Socialist Party candidate Satyanarayan Sah is mentioned. Kamta is angry: "A vote-cutter!" He scolds Vishwamohan too. JD(U), then RJD, sometimes BJP, sometimes the bungalow symbol. Nitish has done a great deal for women: thirty-three seats in every hundred and bicycles for girls.

"He's from the Pathak hamlet." He hands the leaflet back. "Not the lantern—the lotus." "I say lantern." "He says lotus. Lotus."

"What did Modi say?" Things intended to defame Lalu: kidnapping, rape, murder; people shutting themselves indoors at dusk. People mimic Modi and Lalu.

"If the BJP wins, it will abolish reservation." Mohan Bhagwat said that reservation should be reviewed. "It amounts to the same thing: Kamandal against Mandal."

MLC Harun Rashid asks, "What percentage of the population are Brahmins? Only two or two and a half per cent, isn't it? And in government jobs—they are everywhere!"

Chandesari comments that Safina has become much fairer. "All parties take money before giving out tickets. She was late; by then the tickets had been sold." Chandesari begins to gaze at every part of Safina's body. "The BJP wants to drive Muslims out. Muslims are afraid," Safina says. "Just as Hitler massacred the Jews, Modi will cut down the Miyas. Vultures will circle over this country."

"The BJP is spending recklessly." Jamil says, "Modi is a first-class liar!" Ramdhan is concealing something.

Prabhas comes today and hands over seven thousand rupees for booth expenses. There are two booths.

"Only the BJP will build the Ram temple." "Did you elect them merely to build a temple?" "I will vote for Modi." "A confirmed blind devotee!"

Suryanarayan is a Communist. "Nitish is two-faced: one face towards the BJP, the other towards the RJD."

Kamal Das supports the BJP. "A fifty-six-inch chest!" "Where has Pakistan ever dared stand up to India? It will be pushed towards China!" Everyone laughs at Ramdev's words.

"Modi might even attack Pakistan for votes." "Why would the BJP fight a war? Wouldn't it do so for Hindus?" "Send Muslims to Pakistan!" Lal Pathak explodes. "The nationalist Lal has arrived! Now only the Manusmriti-minded lot remain." Dina Pathak says no accusation of corruption has been made against Modi. "Modi is corruption incarnate," comes the reply. Sudhir offers tea. Kamta's generosity completely changes the mood.

Campaigning is over. Everything is quiet, yet beneath it all things smoulder like a heap of chaff.

People begin queuing an hour before polling opens. Bechna coaxes women voters with sweets. Polling is slow in the Supaul market area. The news worries BJP supporters, for the lotus has more voters in town.

Safina arrives to vote. "Come tomorrow," Chandesari says and goes away. Safina smiles. Early next morning Chandesari goes to Navtol and talks with Safina about the election. "The BJP says we'll win; the alliance says we'll win. Now let whatever happens happen." Safina will leave for Delhi in two or three days. Chandesari asks when she will return. Safina says, "The BJP people create a new outrage every day." "Will you go on living with your heart defeated like this?" Chandesari asks. Safina is startled. "Better to die fighting. Dying while fighting—that is living."

A Rereading of Ghardekhiya, the Rajkamal Monograph (Nit Naval Rajkamal), Banait Bigarait, Gulo, Ramta Jogi, Madar, and Bhot

From the samples of *Ghardekhiya*, the Rajkamal monograph (*Nit Naval Rajkamal*), *Banait Bigarait*, *Gulo*, *Ramta Jogi*, and *Bhot* cited above, the reader will have recognised Subhash Chandra Yadav's style: his use of symbols and symbolic signs, the continuously shifting centre of the narrative circle, and his images made of sight and sound. A folk deity such as the Salhes *bhagta* enters the writer's being and begins to feel and probe, to pull out everything that lies hidden, and to record it.

Subhash Chandra Yadav's style, then, is the style of the *bhagta*—a devotee or ritual medium.

Yet in the splendour of *Ghardekhiya* (written in 1975), Sukhdev had cheated so many people of their money in the election. That episode becomes the novel *Bhot* in 2022. There is, of course, a difference between 1975 and 2022: in *Bhot* the protagonist says, "Mannu-bhai, elections used to be so pleasant and peaceful. Now they are a scramble of self-interest." But even in the work of 1975 the observation was: "How can Sukhdev, an illiterate man, earn so much? How many people has he cheated of their money in the election?" *Dhundh Mein Ghatna*, from *Ghardekhiya* (written in 1971), recalled Samuel Beckett's *Waiting for Godot*: it could

have become a postmodern novel. Following the pattern of Yadav's *Ghardekhiya*, Jagdish Prasad Mandal wrote a *Ghardekhiya* in his own way. Thus one text entered into dialogue with another written by an author who, although almost the same age (one year older), began writing thirty years after Yadav.

His text, then, converses with itself across time and space, as well as with the texts of other writers.

From Subhash Chandra Yadav's Ghardekhiya:

"The young man had only recently come back to the village from Calcutta. If a message were sent to summon him immediately, the expense would be borne by his family. He would come ten days before the wedding season; those who wished to see him could see him then."

Now consider this passage from Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Ghardekhiya:

"Nagesar brought both pairs of dhotis from the courtyard and put them before him. Seeing the dhotis, Doman said, 'My dear co-father-in-law, however poor I may be, I have preserved my honour. How could I wear a dhoti at my daughter's in-laws' door?' Lukhiya, who had made a small opening in the thatch, was watching. Hearing Doman, she called from behind the door, 'Tell him that the house will belong to his daughter only when she comes here; until then, surely it is ours. I am giving it to him.' Doman laughed aloud: 'Will she become my co-mother-in-law only when my daughter comes into this house, or is she one already?'"

Just as Riniya picks up *amathi*, *karchi*, or *patlo* wherever she finds them, so Subhash gathers facts from every direction and fashions narratives and grand narratives. The protagonist of *Gulo* is therefore not Gulo but Riniya: the novel begins with her and ends with her. Riniya earned that position for herself. The author had assigned her the role of a supporting performer, but through her devotion she compelled him to make her the heroine. Consider the conflict between Gulo's daughter's and younger son's attitudes towards household labour: the girl is always running, now to the house, now to the grove; the boy sleeps until eight o'clock.

And when Gulo steals bamboo and sells it for five hundred rupees, Riniya buys a young goat with that money. The writer does not explicitly say it is the very same five hundred rupees, but the ease with which Gulo gives Riniya the money brings her self-confidence to the fore.

Gulo's father left Gulo small and large hoes, spades, digging irons, sickles, axes, spears, and lances. There were smoke from the hearth, deceit and manipulation, and Gulo had to settle on government land.

Riniya suffered more than anyone over Gulo's death. That is why the writer gives her a presence at both the beginning and the end.

Gulo's eldest son migrates to Punjab for employment. The whole market belongs to Rajinder the dealer's relative by marriage, Inra Gandhi, and his four sons. Then go beyond the market to Bela, Bina, and Sonak. Gulo receives two invitations with two betel nuts: one to the wedding of Lalo Pandit's granddaughter, and one to that of his sister-in-law's daughter. Gulo's in-laws live in Bela; his wife is called Belawali. Earlier, Gulo's asthma was aggravated by his habitual smoking of ganja; the drug trade must therefore have been taking place all around. To fulfil the wedding invitation he will have to present a sari, petticoat, blouse, and 251 rupees. He goes to Sonak with Chhotua and Riniya. Gulo's elder daughter Runiya is married in Bina. Runiya comes straight from Bina and wants to take her sister Riniya to her marital home. But Riniya refuses: people will say that her father has become ill, that the family's days have grown hard, and that she has come to her sister's house to feed herself. She weeps intensely. Gulo is startled: how has the girl come to understand all this? At the end, Riniya realises that Gulo's mind is deeply troubled. She comes home early in the morning. Her mother asks about the previous night's worship. Riniya does not feel like describing what happened there. Instead she says, "Mother, give me some money, please. I'll bring medicine for Father."

Gulo goes to Sonak for his niece's wedding. He is influential there, and his body language changes. His wife remains subdued, but he scolds and orders people about. If the marriage goes ahead, well and good; otherwise there will be an uproar.

To show the available means of earning a living, the novelist takes us to Malhad's *chaap*, where Gulo's daughter-in-law, Kandahawali, finds new work harvesting fox nuts (*makhana*). Chhotua works in Dashrath Mandal's rice mill. Green gram is to be sown; the ploughman demands 250 rupees for ploughing, levelling, and preparing the field. Then the author begins Gulo's dying with a cough: there is talk of uprooting tuber crops from two *katthas* of land for two hundred rupees.

For an account of family relationships and the troubles of old age, go to Sukhba. He drove his mother out of the house and brought her back only when he was disgraced in public. She is the paternal aunt-in-law of Inra Gandhi.

To glimpse the local culture, observe service to Kalibandi, *bhagait* ritual performance, and *phulhasi*. After this, there will no longer be even a plastering with *kush* grass.

Gulo will ask the orchard owner for a torch. If it is refused, he will not allow him to enjoy a single mango or *luchi*. And look further: bamboo cannot be bought for less than 150 rupees, but when Gulo steals and sells it, he must let it go for a mere hundred.

There are other thieves as well. A thief has stripped all the *luchi* fruit from a whole tree. A certain Thakur is a habitual thief. There is, therefore, a distinction between Gulo's theft of bamboo and the Thakur's stealing. Gulo's principal trade is his tea stall; he steals bamboo perhaps once a year, whereas the Thakur steals professionally. Riniya, Jhuniya, and Barasserwali steal *luchi*. "That Brahmin will catch me?" says Barasserwali, for the entire grove belongs to Brahmins.

The orchard is owned by someone else. In tribal regions, the forest belongs to the government, and the Forest Act recognises tribal people's right to gather firewood, *mahua*, and other forest produce. But the grove in Supaul is not government land. The local proletariat is thus worse off, because the Forest Act does not apply here. Once Riniya brought some tree-ripened mangoes, and the owner gave her fifty rupees. The owner's wife also gave her something to eat.

Dashrath Mandal's co-brother's son is in Nepal, and a marriage proposal comes for Riniya. But Gulo asks for four months' time. Arjunma is useless, yet he will consult him. Dashrath Mandal has money, but Gulo does not say yes at once: he will ask Arjunma. This means the institution of family consultation remains alive.

Riniya, then, is close to Gulo, but the daughter-in-law who had left after a quarrel is not altogether distant either. Look: Kandahawali arrives. "Papa, call the mason who came yesterday. He will repair it. We'll pay whatever it costs."

The author carries the reader both far away and close at hand. Sometimes Gulo is at the centre, sometimes Riniya, sometimes Kandahawali.

In *Ramta Jogi*, Subhash Chandra Yadav encounters things that many people experience elsewhere outside India: cars stopping when they see a pedestrian at a zebra crossing, as in Singapore. If you visit Europe, vehicles at a three-way junction will stop when they see you standing at the corner. Here at home drivers press ahead, expecting those approaching from behind to show courtesy. The author smokes a great deal. He discovers that in those countries regulations prohibit smoking in completely or partially enclosed places. Not smoking in public places has now become accepted in India too. Once people used to blow rings of cigarette smoke in offices; now, if someone tries to smoke furtively even in a bathroom, others glare at him. The protagonist of *Ghardekhiya* also smokes heavily, so the smoking habit seems old and persistent in the writer. His daughter-in-law Madhulika is anxious about it. Calls keep coming from Supaul. The District Magistrate speaks to him, asking only how he is, and only then does he feel reassured. Evidently people still find it hard to believe that the police and administration might simply inquire after their well-being.

In *A House for One Day* (1973), from *Ghardekhiya*, the psychoanalytic method was employed. In *Pilgrimage* (1969), also from *Ghardekhiya*, the storyteller relates the story of Balbawali's courtyard. No doctor will call her mad … but she is mad.

This method acquires a wider scope in *Madar* (2021). Raghunath was unmistakably mad; Madan is not. Consider also the feminist reading: Madan's wife Radha passes in the first division, yet even with her education she cannot prevent Madan from asserting control over her body. She returns, gives up her job, and is murdered. In an attempt to prevent that killing the writer brings Shanichari forward: "Papa, don't kill Mother!" Yet the writer gives Madan no benefit of the doubt: he declares that Madan is not mad. Madan nevertheless finds refuge in his maternal uncle's in-laws' house, among powerful men whose middle brother-in-law is the leader of criminals. They shelter him. Why? The reader understands: they can get him to commit crimes. Thus the writer builds an atmosphere and leaves the reader free to read and reread the narrative.

Leave aside Derrida's deconstruction: here even the fields have been divided and broken up. Madan's father Kamesar Azad had passed Intermediate in his day. His father and uncle once lived together, cultivating fifty or sixty *bighas*. But when Kamesar's uncle died, the family property was partitioned, and Kamesar received five *bighas*.

The same process operates in language. Speakers of the *thethi* or *pachhpaniya* variety will continue to pronounce and write *Punjab* as *Panjab*; and even when the supposedly elite circle around Kedar Kanan pronounces *dengu*, English speakers correct it to *dengi*. Latin and Sanskrit grammars stabilised languages, yet even today Marathi speakers need a commentary to read Saint Dnyaneshwar's Marathi *Dnyaneshwari*.

Derrida's deconstruction regards sound, history, and culture, along with language, as components of a text.

In *Gulo* you may feel that no one is an exploiter and no one is exploited. Language creates this impression: Gulo will not let the orchard owner enjoy even a single *luchi*; he cuts away bamboo, and so on. Yet the surrounding circumstances remind us that Supaul is not a forest region and the owners are Brahmins. Dashrath Mandal, however, owns the rice mill, and non-Brahmins conduct trade throughout the crossroads and markets. A holy man says that someone has scattered *mar-chhaur* at the house. He gives an amulet, but it proves useless. When the amulet turns out to be a fraud, they grow angry. You might think superstition has ended, but then come service to Kalibandi, *bhagait*, and *phulhasi*. There will no longer be even a coating of *kush* grass. Culture has changed, and so has the economy.

Read "Kathak Banal Lok" in *Ghardekhiya*, and you will feel as though you are reading *Gulo*. The government will provide compensation for a collapsed house. We have already seen in *Madar* how a feminist interpretation emerges when Radha secures a first division at the Intermediate examination—which means she must have done so at matriculation as well. The same text can be read in several ways. Gulo Mandal's caste is not specified; draw whatever conclusion you wish from his surname. Mandal of the Mandal Commission was a Yadav, whereas Mandals in West Bengal are counted among Dalits. Kedar Kanan has seen Subhash Chandra Yadav at Gulo's tea shop and read Kumar Pawan's "Paith," but villagers told the critics, "You have read that story; we have just seen it happening in our village." In *Madar* the writer is still more circumspect. Kamesar's father and uncle once owned fifty to sixty *bighas* of land; after committing the murder, Madan goes to his maternal uncle's in-laws, who are powerful men. Thus *Gulo* allows several readings, as does *Madar*. This is what Jacques Derrida's deconstruction suggests. In South India the priests of several tribal societies have become Brahmins. Those who serve Kalibandi or perform *bhagait* and *phulhasi* rituals may be Brahmins or non-Brahmins. A person speaking without fieldwork will ask how a Brahmin could serve a *gahbar* or become a *bhagta*, yet in Rudrapur village (via Tulapatganj, Madhubani district), Brahmin *bhagaits* perform service at the *gahbar*. Among the Satar (Santhal) people spread across Mithila, Murmu priests recite invocations in a particular cadence from texts they associate with the period of the Indus Valley civilisation: Santhal people themselves will tell you this. It is one way of asserting the antiquity and continuity of a script, a history, and a civilisation. Again and again two opposing positions enter into conversation; the centre shifts according to place, time, and people, with no fixed centre. Literature, folk culture, oral tradition, history, and science mingle.

After the British left, Indians began redefining their history, culture, and theoretical foundations. But since Rigvedic times India has also had a parallel tradition, in the forms of *narashamsi* and narrative. In Maithili, however, people with a particular mentality wanted to occupy the entire space and crush it beneath the weight of their ignorance. With Michel Foucault's disciplinary institutions in view, that is no longer possible, and the internet has a particular importance here. It became apparent, however, that women and deprived communities had too little presence in the internet's linguistic spaces. The parallel current in Maithili therefore worked especially hard on this, and the results are now visible to everyone. The mainstream once refused even to notice or listen to the parallel current; today it desires the parallel current to take notice of it.

This came about through democracy, which rests on voting. Let us turn now to *Bhot*. It, too, admits several readings. You have seen how many

kinds of political combinations take shape in this short novel. No centre is permanent. On the ground the parties oppose one another; at the top an entirely different decision has been made.

The feminist discussion now turns around. In *Madar*, Radha passes in the first division, yet her neck is cut with a sickle. Nitish, by contrast, is doing a great deal for women. Why? Because they are fifty per cent of the electorate. You will already have read in *Gulo* that Riniya received five hundred rupees for a school uniform. Now, in *Bhot*, there is thirty-three per cent reservation for women and bicycles for girls. Thus, when the Grand Alliance of RJD, Congress, and JD(U) puts forward a candidate, the protagonist says it is essential to tell the women that voting for the lantern will still make Nitish chief minister. Voting and elections have a thousand defects, but once every five years they stir a new social element into motion. Marginalised groups, including women, experience a sense of growing power. Muslims are alienated from the BJP, Brahmins from the Grand Alliance; the BJP is called the Banias' party; all parties are said to sell their tickets. All these conversations take place both at Pipra's tea stalls and in Lutyens' Delhi. I recall the child labourer in the film *Chillar Party*, who says: "Everyone is taught not to tell lies, and so on. But when they grow up they all lie. Then what difference does it make, sir, whether one person has studied and another has not?"

Gulo: Art and Language

Gulo: Art and Language is edited by Taranand Viyogi, whom I call neo-Brahminical, and Kedar Kanan, whom I call Brahminical. Both have received Sahitya Akademi awards and substantial assignments.

Not a single writer of *pachhpaniya* or *thethi* was invited to contribute an article to the book, because those writers belong to the parallel current, the antagonist of both editors' Brahminical and neo-Brahminical orientations. People of these two orientations may abuse one another, but they unite when confronting the parallel current. Hence this is a *bhatbari* —a collective self-serving feast, as will become clearer below.

Kedar Kanan supplied a nine-page introduction, "The Tale of the Last Destitute Human Being," to the sixty-seven-page *Gulo*. In *Gulo: Art and Language* that burden has now been placed on Taranand Viyogi's shoulders, in the form of a five-page preface. According to Subhash Chandra Yadav, Viyogi's ideology lacks stability; in my view it is quite stable. It is the very same ideology of blackmail as Kedar Kanan's. Brahminical institutions have many faults, and those faults make them vulnerable to blackmail. There is hardly a Brahminical institution that Taranand Viyogi does not attack every few months, only to praise it lavishly once he receives an honour. I cite Chetna Samiti and the Sahitya

Akademi as examples. He writes elsewhere: "The creators of Brahminism may be Brahmins, but there are *pachhpaniya* people and Dalits in its grip too. How else could it happen that nearly two hundred Dalit-*pachhpaniya* writers in Maithili write precisely the same things, in the same manner, which serve the fulfilment of Brahminism's desires? You may see such a Dalit presiding over a Brahmin association and receiving honours there." You may feel that he is writing about himself. His language, literature, subjects, supposed ghazals, duplicity, pursuit of awards, and behaviour are all, in my view, thoroughly Brahminical. People have seen him presiding over gatherings of Brahminical institutions and receiving their honours.

Subhash Chandra Yadav, however, stood firm, for he has an ideology of his own.

The five-page preface to *Gulo: Art and Language* does not advance the criticism of *Gulo*. Rather, it advances an agenda of blackmail directed at Brahminical institutions. This time the target is the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad of Calcutta. Why the attempt will be futile should become clear below.

First, Harimohan Jha, not Yatri, was targeted by Brahminical institutions and individuals. Ramanath Jha was Harimohan Jha's enemy; he subjected Harimohan to gaslighting. After Maithili entered the Sahitya Akademi, Harimohan Jha stopped writing in Maithili. There was no question of awarding him a prize. (For details see my book *Rajdeo Mandal: Maithili Writer*, also available through the Videha archive at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.) http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm

Mahakavi Vidyapati Thakur (1350–1435)—distinct from Vidyapati, the earliest poet of Maithili preceding Jyotirishwar, and a writer in Sanskrit and Avahattha—Vidyapati Thakkur, of the Bishfi–Kashyap line, was a court poet of King Shivasimha and an author in Sanskrit and Avahattha. His many enduring works include *Kirtilata*, *Kirtipataka*, *Purusha Pariksha*, *Gorakshavijaya*, and *Likhanavali*. He is different from the early Maithili poet Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishwar. The image was commissioned by the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Kolkata, from an artist whose name has, for reasons unknown, been kept secret for sixty or seventy years.

But the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad was an institution close to Yatri. He was close to Ramanath Jha and to the Sahitya Akademi as well. He was regularly the chief guest at Brahminical organisations. Those organisations had a problem with Harimohan Jha, not with Yatri.

Taranand Viyogi has no evidence of any allegation made by Yatri against the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad. He therefore begins telling fanciful tales and introduces the abusive language of Mohan Bharadwaj. In my

assessment, the allegations of villainy and of deliberately misplacing manuscripts levelled against the Parishad by Mohan Bharadwaj and Taranand Viyogi amount to accusations of criminal conduct. Do Bharadwaj or Viyogi have evidence? No. The Mithila Sanskritik Parishad has many other shortcomings, but without government help it published the writings of Yatri and Manipadma. In my view neither Bharadwaj nor Viyogi has shown such ethical commitment. Mohan Bharadwaj is no longer alive to apologise, but if Taranand Viyogi has any ethical sense left, he should immediately apologise to the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad. Viyogi wastes his time attacking the institution. It is openly Brahminical, like Chetna Samiti and Vidyanath Jha 'Vidit', whose work he praises lavishly after his own interests have been served. But the Parishad does not have the money to print a manuscript the moment one is placed before it. Nagarjun, the author of *Balchanma*, had no problem with the book; nor does his son Shobhakant (whom Yatri used to call Shobha Mishra) regard it as a Maithili book, and for that reason it is not included in *Yatri Samagra* published by Rajkamal Prakashan. The Mithila Sanskritik Parishad is not a wealthy institution like Chetna Samiti. It publishes books when subscriptions or donations arrive; there is no room for a conspiracy theory. Once a month it opens a room in Kishorikant Mishra's Navin Printing Press for its monthly *Baisar* gathering. Expecting an honour from the institution by means of blackmail is therefore pointless. Third, because it is not based in Bihar, it does not share even the slight apprehension that Bihar Brahmins may feel about the state's present politics.

He then remembers that this is supposed to be a volume of criticism devoted to Subhash Chandra Yadav's *Gulo*, funded, in my account, by Yadav's money, and returns to the novel. But soon he wanders off again without naming Jagdish Prasad Mandal. There are two reasons for not naming people in Brahminism and neo-Brahminism—no, three: first, a lack of courage; second, a lack of evidence, which leads to vague phrases such as "some people" being used to advance an ideological story; and third, an inferiority complex, a fear that naming the person will increase that person's reputation. These are three different situations. Viyogi writes, "The way novels are being brought out wholesale in Maithili …" This is another indication, to me, of his neo-Brahminical outlook: "How could another non-Brahmin besides me win the Sahitya Akademi Award? I am talented by birth, but he …" Yet he will not name the person. Kedar Kanan did the same when he wrote, without naming Surendra Jha 'Suman', Chandranath Mishra 'Amar', Ramanath Jha, Vidyanath Jha 'Vidit', Mayanand Mishra, and others: "People who apply enormous sandal-paste marks on their foreheads consider corrupting the language to be a virtue." Perhaps one day he will acquire the courage to name them. Many of them

are or were close to the two editors. How, then, can they expect readers to believe that they are marginalised? I record these facts to preserve historical accuracy. Brahminism and neo-Brahminism, through similar forms of duplicity, nourish one another; both cooperate in resisting the parallel current.

In the five-page preface that Taranand Viyogi contributes to *Gulo: Art and Language*, a mere five lines concern *Gulo* itself.

Kedarnath Chaudhary expressed his inability to write an article. His discussion of a letter from Phanishwar Nath Renu was, however, welcome.

Mantreshwar Jha has filled pages. He finds *Gulo* moving and its portrayal accurate. I cannot see why paper needed to be spent on saying merely this.

Rajmohan Jha, too, has been a favourite storyteller of Ganganath Gangesh. The two editors could have edited that material. They might have written about it when the government commissioned them to edit Rajmohan Jha, but they apparently left the lines in because Subhash Chandra Yadav is also Ganganath Gangesh's favourite. Yet this book is not even about Subhash Chandra Yadav in general; it concerns only his *Gulo*. Now the reader may understand how the two editors filled 202 pages with articles around a five-page review of a sixty-nine-page *Gulo*. After a page and a half, Gangesh does, admittedly, come to *Gulo*.

Shobhakant (probably Shobha Mishra) admits that he does not belong to any literary genre as a practitioner, but he has written a good summary.

Ramlochan Thakur published *Gulo* in *Mithila Darshan*. After giving a few facts about Mithila, he contributes a reminiscence.

Ashok is primarily a fiction writer and has enjoyed the work, but he has not produced criticism. Narayan-ji also merely polished up a memoir.

Kedar Kanan's memoir reminded me of the Japanese novelist Haruki Murakami's *Novelist as a Vocation*, a book about how novels are written. There is little of critical value in the memoir, but it would be something new if Subhash Chandra Yadav or another novelist offered such a text to readers.

Taranand Viyogi himself does not know what he wishes to write. Filling pages is his aim; by using phrases like "people" and "some people," he keeps his options open. I partly agree with his statement that Maithili criticism took a foolish path after Ramanath Jha. It is with Ramanath Jha that mainstream criticism—of which Viyogi and his associate Mohan Bharadwaj are part—took that foolish path. For evidence, see the Sahitya Akademi-sponsored book *Maithili Patra Patrika*, in which their Brahminical and neo-Brahminical perspectives become clearer; Bharadwaj

makes allegations of villainy against the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, yet they themselves acted similarly in that book. (For further details see my *Rajdeo Mandal: Maithili Writer*, available at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm in the Videha archive.) Here too the ideological opposition between Taranand Viyogi and Subhash Chandra Yadav comes into view. In *Nit Naval Rajkamal*, Yadav called Ramanath Jha's criticism traditionalist and said that he had failed to do justice to Rajkamal Chaudhary.

Ramesh places Lalit, Kishun, and Mayanand on the same scale—yet how different Lalit is from Kishun and Mayanand! He must maintain a balance or his article will not be published. In the mainstream, "criticism" means praise.

Krishnamohan Jha 'Mohan' writes yet another summary. Vaidyanath Jha does not even know the names of Maithili novelists. Kumar Manish Arvind has only just finished *Gulo* and sets about producing a "balanced" assessment under the name of criticism: "The novel's style is not especially developed. Its construction is not very tightly organised. Everything is said, one item after another, in sequence. There is no effort at binding the whole together. Yet the language is so precise ..." Then comes another balancing gesture: yes, this language is the truly authentic language. Critics like him, who have not read the Maithili literature of the parallel current but immediately take up their pens, will naturally remain astonished.

The single article of real value in the collection is Vidyanand Jha's "Hanging On, Yet Alive: *Gulo*, a Grand Narrative of Survival." He strikes a blow at Kedar Kanan, Taranand Viyogi, and others when he says, "This is not pornography of suffering." He offers a meaningful observation on the book's slender form. This is not merely the grand narrative of a deprived class; it is the grand narrative of Mithila. Vidyanand Jha should enter the field of criticism, but, fearing exclusion by the mainstream, he may not be able to do so, since he is accustomed to the easier path. Nevertheless, the impact of his intervention will echo in the ears of both editors for a long time.

Raman Kumar Singh, like Taranand Viyogi, is in the habit of patronising others. Such critics seem to imagine a great commotion, then a moment of "Yada yada hi dharmasya ...," followed by the advent of Viyogi and Raman Kumar Singh to save the world. Anyone who criticises them is then declared Brahminical. Such people are what I call neo-Brahminical. Their main occupation is writing book notices, which they name reviews: the cover is good, the content good, the portrayal beautiful, the language good. Everything is very fine, very beautiful.

Amid the lamentations of the neo-Brahminical camp, however, Arun Kumar Singh writes: "About the language of the Maithili story collections *Ghardekhiya*, published in 1983, and *Banait Bigarait*, published in 2009, I once asked the learned author during his stay in Mysore …"

"… and he said that behind the language of his stories lies a regional atmosphere, what I call the atmosphere of the soil." This also opens up Vidyanand Jha's criticism, which I have described as a blow to the two editors.

In "An Epic of the Toiling Bahujan Society," Satish Verma shows all the world's economic theories failing. He quotes:

"Gulo's son Chhotua placed fire in his mouth. Gulo was covered with earth. Among the women watching the spectacle, one Muslim woman said to another, 'Are these people Hindus or Muslims? They give fire, and they bury as well.' The second Muslim woman replied, 'O Allah! Did you see? They took him away once to bury him, then they buried him again. Where will they get money twice? Do Hindus have no religion at all?' A third Muslim woman said, 'What use is religion? If there is money, children and families can be supported.'"

Verma delivers his judgment: "Like Kabir, he enters into a religious-political dialogue with society." This is a sound conclusion. The first speaker, like the mullah who gives the call to prayer, begins with an assertion of Muslim superiority; the next speaker corrects it politically. And that next speaker, in Satish Verma's understanding, is Subhash Chandra Yadav as Kabir.

Arunabh Saurabh's "An Unvarnished Account of Tormented Poverty" resumes the lament: "Very few novels are being written in Maithili." The verdict is issued, although the facts indicate the opposite: nowadays novels are being written more often than any genre except poetry. Yet he has a precaution ready in case novels are indeed being written: "Even when they are, they do not seem particularly capable of connecting directly with the reader's anguish and restlessness." Such are the problems that arise from writing articles without reading or research. After two or three pages of complaint, he too remembers that he is supposed to write about *Gulo*. The fault is not his alone: it lies with the two editors, who take editing to mean nothing more than proofreading. Even after that, the complaining does not end; it exposes his lack of reading, especially of the literature of the parallel current.

Ashish Chaman writes: "The background of this story comes from 'The Last Destitute Person in Society', and the account is given exactly in their own voices." I have already written that Kedar Kanan's introduction obstructs the reading of *Gulo*. Ashish Chaman's article shows that the

introduction has not only obstructed but also distorted and influenced its interpretation.

Raghunath Mukhiya offers "Thoughts on the Maithili Language on the Pretext of *Gulo*," but leaves the entire burden on Subhash Chandra Yadav and the parallel current. Raghunath Mukhiya himself, like Taranand Viyogi, will continue writing "pure" Maithili.

Taranand Viyogi is still not satisfied. He brings another article, "Pachhpaniya Maithili: A Discussion from the Ground—A Facebook Post, Responses, and Controversy." I do not know what job he does; he seems to spend the whole day on Facebook. But he engages in no discussion about Maithili there: he quickly begins to whine and quarrel. Even the discussions that do occur in the mainstream rarely draw more than five or ten comments. In the Videha Facebook group we had banned more than two hundred Brahminical and neo-Brahminical IDs. Today those are inactive accounts, because we exposed the deception. They could nevertheless become active again, and the parallel current keeps an eye on these sleeper cells. The point remains that Brahminism and neo-Brahminism do little work and rely on manufacturing an atmosphere. I record this to show that there are seldom more than five to seven people in a discussion. To call those responses a "controversy" is simply to pat oneself on the back. I am forced to repeat myself: "The entire burden is left on Subhash Chandra Yadav and the parallel current, while Raghunath Mukhiya and Taranand Viyogi go on writing pure Maithili." To portray oneself as the victim and associate oneself with *pachhpaniya* Maithili, while also participating in the gaslighting of Subhash Chandra Yadav, conspiring with it, and still claiming to share Yadav's ideology—how many falsehoods must one utter, and how shameless must one be? Such conduct is not possible for everyone. Taranand Viyogi alone seems capable of it. You should read the mutual complaining between the Brahminical and neo-Brahminical camps. Both groups suffer, in my description, from split personalities. They jostle, rub against, and abuse one another (for the differences are bitter); yet against the Videha Maithili literary movement of the parallel current they become one. Brahminism and neo-Brahminism compete in duplicity while continually nourishing one another.

Finally, in "Pachhpaniya Maithili," Subhash Chandra Yadav again strikes at the two Sahitya Akademi Award-winning editors when he writes:

"Once Professor Indrakant Jha telephoned me. 'You should have received the Sahitya Akademi Award long ago. You deserve it. I am an admirer of your stories. Your *Banait Bigarait* stands at the top of the race. But its language is not correct. To receive the prize you will have to submit another collection written in a different language.'" A point worth noting

here is that the first story of *Banait Bigarait* is written in elite Maithili, while all the remaining stories are written in *pachhpaniya* Maithili.

Do you remember the time? It was precisely when the same Sahitya Akademi circle was engaged in its shameless performance under the leadership of "Vidit." At that very time the circle had awarded Taranand Viyogi for his "pure" Maithili, and Viyogi had praised Vidit to the skies. I had written the preface to *Banait Bigarait*, and that book had been sacrificed.

He is the author of "Kathak Banal Lok," which I read in 1983 and 1984 when I was in Classes Nine and Ten. He will remain steadfast. Twenty-five years after *Ghardekhiya*, he was still steadfast in *Banait Bigarait*, and now in *Gulo*, *Madar*, and *Bhot*. And see how events unfolded: Indrakant Jha received a resounding answer when Jagdish Prasad Mandal was awarded the Sahitya Akademi's principal Maithili award for 2021 for the novel *Pangu*, written in *thethi/pachhpaniya* spelling.

Dr Ramanand Jha "Raman" jotted in his notebook: "The Brahmin says, 'I am a Soti'; the Solhkan says, 'I am a Brahmin.' What am I to say about what I am?" The contempt for the Solhkan expressed in this note is nothing other than a linguistic manifestation of caste hostility and hatred.

Ramanand Jha "Raman" replied to Subhash Chandra Yadav on 10 December 2022, after my *Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav (Part 1)* appeared in Videha on 1 December 2022. Dinesh Yadav opposed Raman's response from Nepal, while Lalitesh Mishra supported it from India.

Ramanand Jha "Raman": Surveying the Fields Without Having Studied Surveying

A field is measured by an *amin*, a trained land surveyor. *Amini* is not a song that anyone can sing or hum. It is a discipline. Without learning it, how could one understand the importance of a surveyor's chain and links? Move one link this way or that, and brothers may end up breaking one another's heads. Similarly, anyone who measures language must acquire knowledge of linguistics or the science of language. Only then can that person distinguish a language from a dialect, a mixed language from a creole, and so forth. Only then can one explain the distinctions between spoken and written language, ordinary and literary language, or the language of a character and that of the author.

Ramanath Jha holds that "the Mithila language is not a language born today whose form may settle with time. It has had a written tradition for six hundred years. Yet over the past fifty years, under Hindi influence, it has been corrupted. First its script was lost; now the very form of the language is on the verge of destruction. A language does not belong to a single

person, so that everyone may write it in every imaginable way; then it would cease to be a language."

The protection and use of common property require discipline. Just as field irrigation depends on a water channel (*pauti*), so a language's prestige and acceptance on national and international platforms depend on proper channels. The surveyors of the Mithila language have carried out this work.

George Abraham Grierson identified the Mithila language through linguistic analysis, declared it an independent language, and specified the characteristics of its dialects. The great grammarian Dinbandhu Jha, Mahamahopadhyaya Umesh Mishra, Acharya Ramanath Jha, Dr Subhadra Jha, Pandit Govind Jha, Dr Ramavatar Yadav, Uday Narayan Singh "Nachiketa," Yogendra Prasad Yadav, Dr Sunil Kumar Jha, and others studied that discipline and brought the Mithila language international recognition and prestige. Today, however, such a clamour has arisen—or been made to arise—that no one recognises anyone else. They respect neither Pandit Govind Jha nor Dr Ramavatar Yadav. They are Maithili poets, fiction writers, novelists, critics, politically motivated social workers —and, above all, self-appointed linguists who have never studied the discipline.

Consider Dinesh Yadav's reply:

"First of all, identify the language's hollow pretenders; reaching a conclusion will be easier. We need grammar, but what kind? We need a standard, but how should it be determined? People have rejected the Brahmin-settlement style, its commentarial language, and its supposedly standard form. Maithili speakers are no longer the complete fools they once were taken for; they have become discerning. I write and read Maithili, but these gentlemen who determine the standard refuse to recognise my speech, style, and dialect. We must therefore reject such old-fashioned thinking and impoverished mentality and move ahead afresh. The system in which people receive awards by singing praises and circling powerful patrons as though they were Ganesha must be given its final rites. Unless a sociological and psychological perspective is developed, Maithili will remain fenced in by caste-specific philosophies, beliefs, and ideas. That enclosure can only harm it, again and again. Scientific thinking, equal treatment, recognition of all castes, and inclusion of diverse dialects are the life-saving medicine for Maithili. Let us accept these and move forward; it is not too late. Maithili will shine and sparkle!"

But Ramanand Jha "Raman" received Lalitesh Mishra's support. Notice Mishra's duplicity: he pretends that his remarks are directed not at Subhash Chandra Yadav but at some younger person or Facebook user. I

have therefore called this behaviour "Puranic criticism," dependent on the platform. The criticism changes with the platform: in the *Garuda Purana*, Garuda is placed above Brahma, Vishnu, and Mahesh; in the *Matsya Purana*, Matsya is placed above Brahma, Vishnu, and Mahesh.

Lalitesh Mishra's Support for Ramanand Jha "Raman"

"Not everyone needs guidance. Those very people will guide you themselves. They consider themselves experts in every subject. They have no need of a linguist. Maithili has developed wonderfully. An age endowed with new knowledge has arrived. No one needs to show the way any longer. Displaying one's learning will only invite abuse."

But my mother was no less forthright. A book of Maithili proverbs contained the line, "Ten Brahmins, ten stomachs; ten *rars*, one stomach." She taught me that it was wrong and said it was what Brahmins said. Other groups, she said, had their own version about Brahmins: "Ten Brahmins, one stomach." I do not know what kind of upbringing Ramanand Jha "Raman" and Lalitesh Mishra received.

But both of them know what they are doing, and here I shall expose it. Ramanand Jha "Raman" writes, "Only then can one say that this is a language, that is a dialect, this a mixed language, that a creole, and so on." Do you see any conspiracy in the wording? Let us examine what that conspiracy is.

English is spoken in various forms, as a mother tongue and as a second language. There are also several varieties of pidgin English and creole English. Pidgin English can be divided into two main groups, Atlantic pidgin and Pacific pidgin. Atlantic pidgin English developed in West Africa and spread to the West Indies and the Americas through the slave trade; in those regions pidgin speakers were regarded as stupid and lazy. But this was not true of Pacific pidgin. It developed in Hawaii, Papua New Guinea, and other British colonies out of the necessities of trade. In New Guinea a creole is a national language, for it developed, expanded its vocabulary, and elaborated its sentence structures. What is a pidgin? It is a means of communication between people who speak different languages; a pidgin is not initially anyone's mother tongue. Over time a pidgin may become some people's mother tongue, in which case it is called a creole. English-based pidgins and creoles spread through British colonies, providing communication between English masters and local populations. Pidgins and creoles have been described as nonstandardised varieties of English. These are somewhat limited systems, with restricted structures and vocabularies. Now I imagine you are laughing at Raman's ignorance: he is treating a Maithili with a vocabulary of two thousand words and fifty sentence structures as the original, while calling the Maithili of the

parallel current, with more than a hundred thousand words and more than a thousand sentence structures, a creole. But hold your stomach, for Ramanand Jha "Raman" and Lalitesh Mishra will give you still more occasions for laughter.

Hawaiian Pidgin

English: "Sometimes there is a good road."

Hawaiian pidgin: "Samtem, gud rod get."

English: "Sometimes there are things like bends, angles, right?"

Hawaiian pidgin: "Samtem, olsem ben get, anguru get, no?"

Cameroon Pidgin

English: "Go."

Cameroon pidgin: "Go." (No change.)

English: "Don't go."

Cameroon pidgin: "No go."

English: "They can go."

Cameroon pidgin: "Dem fit go."

English: "They can't go."

Cameroon pidgin: "Dem no fit go."

English: "Nobody came."

Cameroon pidgin: "No man no bin kam."

Nigerian Pidgin

English: "Government! All our roads are ruined completely."

Nigerian pidgin: "Gofrument! All our roads don yamutu finish."

English: "Please make somebody come from the government, even if it is from Kano."

Nigerian pidgin: "Biko make somebody gofument, even if e fit from Kano, come sef."

English: "Anyone who is available, sir, let him just get something done."

Nigerian pidgin: "Anyones at all aflabulu sa, make e jus find somtins done for."

English: "All these roads are in a woeful state."

Nigerian pidgin: "All dis road dem we don wowo finish."

Chinese Coastal Pidgin

English: "He is/was very sick."

Chinese coastal pidgin: "He plenty sick."

English: "I am the chief boy."

Chinese coastal pidgin: "My belong number-one boy."

English: "This is an excellent book."

Chinese coastal pidgin: "Dis a nomba wan good book."

(D. Crystal, *The English Language*, Penguin Books, England, 1990.)

Now let us turn to the conspiracy. What is Ramanand Jha "Raman" trying to say? That language reflects the relationship between master and servant? That pidgin Maithili has become creole Maithili? Or does he mean nothing at all, because he knows nothing about this subject and merely wants to muddle things through ignorance? In my village such talk is called *bakathothi*, empty chatter, and is disapproved of. Ramanand Jha "Raman" is thus attempting to survey fields without having learnt surveying. In support of his position he lists the names of Ramavatar Yadav, Yogendra Prasad Yadav, Sunil Kumar Jha, and others—a practice known in Delhi as "name-dropping," and not held in high regard. This establishes, in my view, that he assembled a bibliography by putting keywords into Google Search without reading the scholars' books. Yogendra Prasad Yadav's English article has also been published electronically in *Videha*. Had Raman read even that, his perspective might have become clearer. Ramavatar Yadav's research supports Subhash Chandra Yadav's position. It is now plain who is attempting to carry out a survey without first learning how to survey.

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes:

"Maithili grammarians constructed grammatical frameworks modelled on Sanskrit and Hindi. They did not consider the distinctive qualities and differences of Dalit Maithili worthy of attention. Dr Ramavatar Yadav is the only linguist who has given the matter some consideration."

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes again:

"Once a programme was held at the Anugrah Narayan Sinha Institute of Social Studies, Patna. It was organised by the Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore. The central concern was the development of the Maithili language. Various speakers presented their ideas about how that development might take place. Dr Meghan Prasad also expressed his views. His language did not employ the degree of honorific address that the group of scholars expected. As a result, he was mocked very rudely in the

middle of his speech for what was deemed his linguistic lapse. The scene disturbed me, and I protested against that kind of linguistic intolerance there and then."

An article presented by Meghan Prasad at that very Central Institute of Indian Languages seminar in Mysore was published without its opening paragraph in *Ghar Bahar*, the journal of Ramanand Jha "Raman's" so-called literary association (an operation at which Raman is expert). The complete article was later published electronically in *Videha*. Do you understand what fact this manoeuvre tried to censor? Meghan Prasad had written that he had repeatedly expressed an interest in translation assignments from the Sahitya Akademi, but—such was the Akademi's supposed affection for him—he had never received a single assignment. You may now understand why Meghan Prasad and Subhash Chandra Yadav are excluded by the mainstream and the Sahitya Akademi, while Taranand Viyogi is acceptable to them.

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes:

"Maithili of the *pag* and *dopata* may pass away, but the Maithili of the round-necked shirt will remain alive."

The image of round-necked-shirt Vidyapati that you have seen in this essay was made by Pankalal Mandal, a recipient of the Videha Award. It represents the Vidyapati of the *Padavali*, the Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishwar; it is also Videha's logo.

The image of Vidyapati in a *pag* and *dopata*, associated with the Sanskrit and Avahattha writings, was commissioned from an artist by the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Kolkata. For reasons unknown, the artist's name has been concealed for sixty or seventy years.

Subhash Chandra Yadav reminded me of my father. Twenty-seven years after his death, I do not know from where the tears have returned to my eyes.

> *I had watched my father embrace truth with the stillness of a steadfast mind.*
>
> *It was then that I understood:*
>
> *There could be no renunciation;*
>
> *this is the path of those who insist on persevering.*

"Mother asked about last night's worship. Riniya did not feel like telling her what had happened there. She said, 'Mother, give me some money, please. I will bring medicine for Father.'" (*Gulo*, novel, 2015.)

"In 1995 I came home from training without any reason. My mind had grown restless. My mother asked about the training, but I did not want to

speak about what had happened there. I asked about my father's state of mind. He was lying asleep on the cot. I would wake him at three o'clock and offer him tea. I had covered the plate of food served for him with another plate. My father was asleep on a Sunday afternoon. I would eat when he woke. Was his mind all right? At three o'clock Mother went with tea to wake Father. … Father did not wake." (A true incident from my life, 1995.)

III. Gopal Jha 'Abhishek' and *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari*: A Literary Study

Abstract

In the contemporary landscape of Maithili literature, Gopal Jha 'Abhishek' has emerged as a vigorous and forthright literary voice whose writing combines the earthy fragrance of village soil with an emphatic global consciousness. His recent poetry collection *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari* (*Come, Let Us Share Our Dreams*, 2021) is a landmark in the Maithili poetic tradition: it stirs the reader's sensibility and compels self-examination. Published by Anupras Prakashan, Madhubani, the poems in this volume are not simply arrangements of words. They are an authentic record of the contradictions of their time, human suffering, political hypocrisy and dreams for the future.

Keywords: Gopal · Abhishek · dream · sharing · literary · study · poetry

Gopal Jha 'Abhishek' and *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari*: A Literary Study

The Poet's Personality and Poetic Philosophy

Gopal Jha 'Abhishek' was born on 15 April 1966 in Murliyachak village, Bisfi block, Madhubani district. As a student of history, he combines a sense of the past with an awareness of contemporary realities in his poetic vision. Before *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari*, he had published a Hindi poetry collection, *Ek Adim Gandh Ki Talash* (*In Search of a Primal Scent*, 2011), and a Maithili collection, *Kaiek Arthame* (*In Several Senses*, 2017), works that attest to the maturation of his poetic craft.

Abhishek's poetic philosophy places *manukhtai*—humanity, or humaneness—at its centre. For him, poetry is not a hymn in praise of any throne or monastic establishment; it is an instrument of resistant communication. In his introduction, 'Lakshya Dhari Pahuch'bait Achhi Kavita' ('Poetry Carries Us Towards the Goal'), the critic Mithilesh Kumar Jha rightly observes that Abhishek's poetry makes its readers sensitive enough to preserve *manukhtai*, the pillar standing at the heart of civilization and culture.

Gopal Jha ‘Abhishek’: Major Works and Biographical Details

Particulars — Information

Place of birth — Murliyachak, Bisfi, Madhubani

Education — M.A. (History)

Maithili poetry collections — *Kaiek Arthame* (2017); *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari* (2021)

Hindi poetry collection — *Ek Adim Gandh Ki Talash* (2011)

Unpublished dramatic works — *Muktiparva*; *Rupnagar*; *Ekta Ar Agni Pariksha*

Award — Acharya Surendra Jha ‘Suman’ National Shikhar Literary Award (2018)

Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari: The Significance of the Title

The collection's title, *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari*, is itself an invitation: an invitation to build a society in which joys and sorrows are shared. In the poet's view, dreaming and sharing dreams are ways of keeping faith with the future. When the world is submerged in the darkness of violence, self-interest and separatism, the very act of dreaming becomes a profound resistance. In ‘Vaiha Swapna Ta Achhi Kavita’ (‘That Very Dream Is Poetry’), the poet makes clear that poetry is a means of preventing dreams from dying.

A Detailed Literary Review of the Poems

Every poem in the collection has a distinct subject and artistic form. The following is a detailed examination of the principal poems.

1. The Voice of Human Sensibility and Compassion

‘Antim Aas’ (‘The Last Hope’): Dedicated to New Zealand's prime minister Jacinda Ardern, this poem presents womanhood as the last refuge of compassion. Whenever the world has taken the road to destruction, the presence of women has come forward as a protective shield. The lines ‘If we have preserved the last hope / it has certainly not been without reason’ underscore the importance of women's leadership and compassion on a global scale.

‘Kona Paratarab He Tathagat’ (‘How Shall We Console Them, O Tathagata?’): Written in memory of the children who died of acute encephalitis syndrome, locally known as *chamki bukhar*, in Muzaffarpur, this poem raises grave philosophical questions. The poet asks Tathagata Buddha how a mother can be consoled when even a handful of mustard

seeds offered in consolation is of no use. The poem makes clear that what is needed in the face of death is not a miracle, but 'medical research' and 'adequate resources'. It is a compassionate indictment of an incapacitated system.

'Dosare Din Jakan' ('As on Any Other Day'): Written against the background of the murder of Priyanka Reddy in Hyderabad, this poem portrays the 'wolf' lurking within human beings. The poet grieves over the way a young woman who had stepped out as she did on any other day could fall into the trap of cunning, vicious men. The poem bears witness to a moment when humanity is put to shame.

2. Political and Social Contradictions

'Saheb' ('The Sahib'): This poem is a biting satire on the caste-mindedness prevalent in Mithila's society. Through surnames such as Jha, Mishra, Pathak, Yadav, Paswan and Thakur, the poet shows people anxiously looking towards the *saheb* of their respective castes. He sharply ridicules the way people's prospects depend on a *saheb*'s likes and dislikes.

'Pag' ('The Ceremonial Headgear'): The *pag*, a symbol of Mithila's honour and dignity, has now become little more than an object for display. The poet suggests placing it in a museum, since it no longer remains on people's heads for very long. This is a serious comment on the hollowness of tradition.

'Karyakarta' ('The Activist'): Depicting political decline, the poet asks where the activists have gone. All that remain, he suggests, are leaders, spectators and unthinking supporters. The definition 'An activist means a goal / in the face of a struggle' has now been forgotten.

'Sarvasammati Banayabak Kramme' ('In the Process of Manufacturing Consensus'): The poet opposes the deprivation carried out in the name of unanimity within a democracy. In his view, consensus can sometimes become a devious means of strangling democracy itself.

3. Innovation in Symbols and Imagery

'Transformer': The poet is skilled in his use of modern imagery. In this poem he explains the balanced coordination of society through conductors and insulators. His ability to see how an ordinary insulating object made of porcelain protects a system from unwanted current reveals an innovative poetic vision.

'Pahar: Ekta Sambhavana' ('Mountain: A Possibility'): The poet sees the mountain not merely as an obstacle but as an 'established adversary'. Only when an enormous opposition confronts us does the possibility of overcoming it arise.

'Phukna' ('The Inflated Thing'): The poem symbolises fanciful schemes and the collapse of dreams. When every feat depends solely on air, its eventual collapse is only natural.

4. Village, Nature and Geography

'Dhar Basabait Rahalae Gam' ('The River's Course Kept Founding Villages'): The poet connects the changing courses of Mithila's rivers with the continuity of life. Where a river's course destroys one village, it also brings another into being. 'The current kept founding villages / and, having founded them, moved on' captures Mithila's enduring reality.

'Pokhari' ('The Pond', sequence 5–8): Ponds, the lifeblood of Mithila, have become dumping grounds for rubbish. The poet is distressed by the silence of both administrators and the public. In the decline of the pond, he depicts the decline of village civilization itself.

'I Chhot-Chhin Gachh' ('This Little Tree'): This poem expresses the poet's faith in the future. So long as leaves remain on the tree, the sign of life remains secure.

5. Global and Philosophical Consciousness

'Jerusalem': This poem expresses the poet's concern about conflict across the world. Rather than asking whom Jerusalem should belong to, the poet advocates 'fighting for everyone's rights'.

'Itihas Kahalak' ('History Said') and 'Itihasak Ijotme' ('In the Light of History'): The poet does not regard history as a weapon for disputes and quarrels. In 'In the Light of History', he admits that it is we ourselves who stand in the dock of history, and accepting our mistakes is the way to do justice to the past.

'Naitikatak Deharipar' ('On the Threshold of Morality'): This poem portrays the way modern technology and the mechanical eye—CCTV and similar devices—have pushed human morality aside. Machines themselves are not subject to moral questioning.

6. The Anguish of Emergency and Displacement

'Ehi Aapatkalme' ('During This Emergency', parts 1–2): This poem is an epic of the suffering endured by migrant workers during the coronavirus period. When great cities discarded the very people who had built them, treating them as flies to be flicked out of milk, the workers' feet endured innumerable hardships on the way back to their native soil. How bitterly ironic was the injunction 'Stay at home! / Stay at home! The mantra of staying at home' for those whose only home in the metropolis was a rented *kholi*, from which they were driven out when they could no longer pay the rent.

'Hamhu Rahab Etahi' ('I Too Shall Live Here'): This poem asserts the right of other living creatures, no less than humans, to inhabit the earth. Destroying nature in the name of development is an invitation to our own destruction.

Craft, Language and the Arrangement of Images

Gopal Jha 'Abhishek' shapes his poetry to suit its subject matter. His language is 'unaffected', without any attempt at a display of erudition. He uses words drawn from ordinary village speech in such a way that they acquire a distinctive force.

Distinctive Features of the Language:

Aspect — Characteristic

Choice of words — An appealing use of unforced, familiar and village vocabulary [1]

Metre — Most poems are in free verse, an appropriate form for expressing modern sensibility

Imagery — Innovative images such as the transformer, the inflated object, the pothole in the road and the manhole

Satire — Sharp, penetrating satire directed at social and political contradictions

One of the great strengths of Abhishek's poetry is its ability to communicate. He brings even the most complex subjects to his readers in an exceptionally simple manner. His poems are marked by the predominance of *prasada-guna*, the quality of clarity and accessibility, which makes an immediate impression on readers.

Thematic Classification of the Poetry Collection

For ease of study, the collection's poems may be divided into the following categories.

Category — Principal Poems

Human sensibility — 'Antim Aas', 'Kona Paratarab He Tathagat', 'Dosare Din Jakan', 'Pradyumna'

Social reality — 'Pag', 'Saheb', 'Jati', 'Bhinne Bathan', 'Vyatha-Katha'

Political consciousness — 'Lakshagriha', 'Karyakarta', 'Sarvasammati', 'Antim Charanak Chunav'

Nature and geography — 'Dhar Basabait Rahalae Gam', 'Pokhari', 'I Chhot-Chhin Gachh'

Love and domestic life — ‘Tahi Bich’, ‘Prem Sang’, ‘Grihasthi’, ‘Ahank Bahanne’

Modernity and contradiction — ‘Transformer’, ‘Dilli Darshan’, ‘Naitikatak Deharipar’, ‘Sarak-Samved’

Major Philosophical and Intellectual Questions

Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari is not merely a collection of poems; it is also a serious philosophical discussion.

1. Poetry as resistance: Abhishek's poetry speaks in a ‘firm voice of resistance’ against injustice. He does not favour passive submission to wrongdoing. In ‘Kono Devasur Sangramak Nahi Banab Sakshi’ (‘I Shall Not Be a Witness to Any War of Gods and Demons’), he makes clear that he will not participate in any war imposed upon him. Rather, he will decide whom to support solely by the criterion of ‘justice and injustice’.

2. Women's consciousness: The poet calls for women's views to be heard and their participation to be ensured. The poem ‘Ek Ber Puchhi Ta Liau’ (‘At Least Ask Her Once’) respects women's power to make decisions.

3. Historical consciousness: As a student of history, the poet knows that pride in a glorious past is not enough. In ‘Takare Ho Jirnoddhar’ (‘Let That Be Restored’), he advocates discarding traditions that are no longer appropriate and preserving those that are worthwhile.

4. Concern for democracy: Poems such as ‘Janata-Forum’ and ‘Antim Charanak Chunavsa Pahine’ (‘Before the Final Phase of the Election’) reveal the poet's anxiety over the public humiliation of democracy and the construction of a *lakshagriha*, a house of lacquer set as a deadly trap.

Assessing Abhishek's Contribution to Maithili Literature

In the present period of Maithili literature, Gopal Jha ‘Abhishek’ is a poet who connects his language to global concerns. When Maithili poetry was accused of remaining confined to village verandas and ponds, Abhishek made Jerusalem, the prime minister of New Zealand and global technology subjects of his poems.

His poems are descriptive in style and provide substantial information about their subjects. His observational gaze is clear, and he is closely acquainted with the disorderly conditions of village life. At the level of language, he is notably alert and careful, giving his poetry both a ‘modern outlook’ and a ‘world view’.

Conclusion

The collection *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari* brings to light a vibrant aspect of Maithili poetry. It testifies to the poet's sensitivity, intellectual resolve and command of language. Alongside its hard-hitting attacks on the contradictions of the present, Abhishek's poetry affirms the resolve to dream of a better future and to share those dreams.

Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari: Philosophical and Linguistic Examination

This work by Gopal Jha 'Abhishek' is not merely an outpouring of feeling. It is a complex *samsarga*, or conjunction, of word and meaning, in which the local life of Mithila and a global consciousness flow in parallel.

1. An Assessment Through Gangesha's Navya-Nyaya and the Criterion of *Avacchedakata*

The principal aim of Navya-Nyaya, developed by Gangesha Upadhyaya in the fourteenth century, was to remove ambiguity from language and render its expression more precise.

The delimitation of dreams: In the collection's title, *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari*, the 'dream' is not merely an imaginary 'content' (*vishayata*, contentness). From the perspective of Nyaya philosophy, the dream here is *kartritva-avacchinna*, delimited by agency. For the poet, the dream is a *sadhya*, something to be accomplished, pervaded by the *hetu*, or reason, of *manukhtai* (humanity). When he says, 'Come, let us share our dreams', he releases the dream from narrow individuality and makes it *samuhikata-avacchinna*, delimited by collectivity.

'Transformer' and *samsargata*: In Abhishek's poem 'Transformer', the coordination of society is explained through the conductors and insulators of electricity. According to the Navya-Nyaya concept of *samsargata* (relationship), a society's existence depends upon a particular relation in which the 'insulator' (ordinary people) becomes the *pratiyogi* (counter-positive) that stops an unwanted 'current'. Here the distinctiveness of an energised society lies in balanced coordination.

2. Harimohan Jha's Framework of 'Linguistic Analysis'

According to Professor Harimohan Jha, words have three powers: *abhidha* (primary denotation), *lakshana* (secondary indication) and *vyanjana* (suggestion).

The use of *lakshana*: This can be observed in poems such as 'Saheb' and 'Pag'. When the poet speaks of placing the *pag* in a museum, the headgear leaves behind its primary denotation (*abhidha*) and conveys the indicated meaning (*lakshyartha*) of a rigid attachment to the past.

The intensity of *vyanjana*: In the context of New Zealand's prime minister, to call woman 'the last hope' in the poem 'Antim Aas' is an instance of purposive indication (*prayojanavati lakshana*), suggesting that compassion alone can offer protection in a global crisis. According to Harimohan Jha's theory of *shabda-bodha*, or verbal cognition, the power of the word here awakens a new *samskara*, or impression, in the reader.

3. The Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur)

The *Videha* framework views literature in terms of an ideological struggle between 'power' and 'the dispossessed'.

The voice of the dispossessed: The sequence 'Ehi Aapatkalme' sketches a 'parallel history' of migrant workers during the coronavirus period. While mainstream history was recording 'statistics', Abhishek's poetry was transforming the pain of the 'dispossessed' into an 'actual philology'.

Historical consciousness: In 'Itihas Kahalak' and 'Itihasak Ijotme', the poet regards history not as 'evidence for a quarrel' but as a 'new chapter of revival'. This accords with the *Videha* perspective that knowledge and truth are 'constructed' (a Foucauldian perspective), and that poetry gives such truth a new form.

4. The Convergence of Indian and Western Critical Theories

Indian poetics (*rasa* and *dhvani*): Abhishek's poetry is characterised chiefly by *prasada-guna*, the quality that makes meaning readily accessible to the reader. In 'Kona Paratarab He Tathagat', *karuna-rasa*, the sentiment of compassion or pathos, reaches its height. Unlike Western 'tragedy', compassion here does not stop at grief: it makes a reasoned demand for 'medical research'. This is an appealing synthesis of Indian *nyaya* and Western scientific rationalism.

Modernity versus tradition: For Abhishek, 'modernity' in Western criticism is not something to be imitated; it is an attitude to life. To call the mountain an 'established adversary' in 'Pahar: Ekta Sambhavana' is to bring Hegelian dialectics into relation with the 'patience' of Indian philosophy.

Conclusion

In its account of verbal cognition (*shabda-bodha*), *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari* resembles an 'indivisible sentence-sphota' (*akhanda-vakya-sphota*): each poem stands apart, yet together the poems constitute a complete discourse of *manukhtai* (humanity). The precision of Navya-Nyaya, the linguistic depth associated with Harimohan Jha, and *Videha*'s parallel-historical perspective establish the book as an enduring document of Maithili literature.

This collection deserves to be read not only by readers of Maithili but by lovers of literature everywhere. Abhishek's poetry connects readers readily to its subjects and compels them to reflect. In short, *Aau Swapna Sajhi Kari* is a 'witness' that speaks the truth of its times without fear.

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Editorial note: Where the original manuscript does not provide a source's year of publication, edition, or full publishing details, no conjectural information has been added.

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All books on Sanskrit and culture by Baldev Upadhyaya, Kapildev Dwivedi, Bharatendu Dwivedi and Radhavallabh Tripathi.

Books on Sanskrit by Charudev Shastri.

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PART II / TOME VI

Maithili Narrative Theory

Principles and Practice

Translated from original Maithili by the author himself

Gajendra Thakur · Videha

PART I

MAITHILI NARRATIVE THEORY

GAJENDRA THAKUR

PART I · THEORY

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Abstract

An adequate criticism of Maithili narrative literature cannot rest on a synopsis, an inventory of a character's virtues and faults, or an account of the work's social message alone. What kind of world of events does a story create? How does narration order, restrict, elaborate, or fragment that world? Beyond the meaning stated in words, what suggestions (dhvani), aesthetic experiences (rasa), and further significations arise? And on what sources do a novel's historical and social claims depend? These are distinct yet interconnected questions. This essay develops a proposed method of Maithili literary criticism called "Evidence-Parity and Parallel Narratology." It rests upon three foundations: the examination of aesthetic form and experience derived from Indian poetics; conceptual precision, distinctions among means of knowledge, and the scrutiny of inference inspired by Gangeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya; and the multiple sources, multiple voices, examination of silences, and uniform critical standards of the Videha perspective on parallel history. The distinctions of modern narratology—story and discourse, temporal order, duration, frequency, focalisation, narrator, narrative level, eventfulness, character networks, space, language, generic hybridity, the reader, and movement

between media—become operative instruments within this threefold confluence. The method does not treat literary invention as historical documentation: truth within the story-world, textual evidence, and external historical truth are separate domains of inquiry. The essay provides analytical principles, a working procedure, a chapter-by-chapter assessment form, an event register, tests of counterarguments, an invented illustrative example, and a glossary. Its purpose is not to impose a single final verdict, but to make possible a criticism that is verifiable, open to re-examination, aesthetically sensitive, and socially responsible.

Keywords: narratology; Maithili; rasa; dhvani; vakrokti; aucitya; Navya-Nyāya; pramāṇa; vyāpti; avacchedaka; Videha; parallel history; narrative time; focalisation; polyphony.

1. Introduction: From Reviewing Stories to Examining Narrative

Maithili possesses a long tradition of stories, novels, folk ballads, narrative poetry, autobiography, and oral storytelling. Yet when a review of a novel stops at saying "the subject is excellent," "the characters are impressive," or "the author has portrayed social reality," it cannot explain to the reader which operations of literary craft produce the work's effect, which events alter the reader's expectations, or which narrative choices render other possibilities invisible. Nor is the mere translation of a European narratological vocabulary sufficient to remedy this deficiency.

The premise of the present proposal is that a literary narrative is simultaneously a constructed world, an arrangement of telling, a composition grounded in felt experience, and a textual intervention available within society. Each of these four dimensions requires a distinct point of entry into analysis. A character's statement may seem entirely credible in literary terms, but that character's account of history does not thereby become evidence of actual history. Equally, a voice missing from the archive may remain unheard within the story, but neither an author's intention nor an actual event can be inferred with certainty from absence alone.

This method is not merely a "mixture" of established disciplines. Its central task is to regulate the possible conflicts among them. The theory of rasa asks: how is an experience aesthetically realised? Narratology asks: from whose perspective, and in what order, is information imparted? Criticism inspired by Navya-Nyāya asks: on what grounds does this conclusion stand, and under what conditions could it fail? Parallel history asks: whose voices have been preserved, whose have not, and how does inequality in the preservation of sources affect the conclusions reached?

The term “evidence-parity” expresses an ethical and scholarly demand: claims made by the powerful or the neglected, claims favoured by the storyteller or preferred by the critic, must all be subjected to explicit and equally examined rules of evidence. “Parallel” does not mean merely adding names from the margins to an established central list. It means reading together the many simultaneous currents of story-making, social causation, focalisation, and the distribution of archives, with attention to their mutual effects. The proposed designation names a new method; it is not the name of an established school propounded by an ancient master.

2. Definition, Scope, and Fundamental Propositions

2.1 Story, Telling, and Narrative

By “story” is meant the possible sequence of states, events, agents, causes, and consequences occurring in an imagined or recounted world. “Telling” is the process by which a speaker, medium, or text presents this material to someone. “Narrative” is the total configuration within which material, selection, sequence, focalisation, language, silence, the reader's inferences, and cultural signs operate together. Distinguishing these three terms prevents “what happened?” from being confused with “how was it told?”

The chronology of a story may be: “First the embankment was built, then the flood came, and finally people fled.” The telling, however, may begin with the flight and only afterwards unfold the remembered history of the embankment. The difference between the sequence of events and the sequence of their narration is an active source of meaning; it ought not to be dismissed as merely “an interesting way of telling it.”

2.2 Four Kinds of Truth-Claim

First, the textual fact: which words, events, references, or statements occur in the printed text and can be identified by page or paragraph. Second, the story-world fact: which event is taken to have occurred within the work, a determination that may depend on the narrator's reliability and the information available to the reader. Third, the interpretative claim: a critical inference concerning symbols, implied meanings, a character's motives, or rasa, for which more than one defensible reading may be possible. Fourth, the external historical claim: a statement about an event, date, institution, social statistic, or document beyond the work; this requires independent sources and source criticism.

If a novel says “one hundred ponds dried up,” that can be a textual fact. Whether so many ponds actually dried up within the story, or whether the narrator exaggerated, is a question of internal reliability. Whether that number of ponds really dried up in the region during the year in question

depends on external sources. Distinct conclusions and distinct markers of uncertainty should be maintained at all four levels.

2.3 Seven Propositions of the Method

One: an assessment of artistic meaning is incomplete without an examination of the mode of narration. Two: an interpretation cannot be decisive unless it exhibits textual evidence. Three: affective experience must not be reduced to mechanical counting. Four: truth internal to the story and truth about external history are different. Five: the investigation of multiple voices, silence, and social location must remain connected to close reading. Six: the limits of each inference, its counterexamples, and its possible qualifying conditions must be stated. Seven: the critic should disclose their own standpoint, selections, evidentiary sources, and openness to revision.

3. Aesthetic Examination Derived from Indian Poetics

3.1 Rasa: The Organisation of Feeling, Not Merely the Naming of an Emotion

Bharata Muni's theory of rasa is to be employed to examine the affective organisation of a story. Questions about the production of rasa are to be raised through the relationships among vibhāva (determinants), anubhāva (consequent manifestations), vyabhicāri-bhāva (transitory states), and sthāyi-bhāva (enduring emotion). The mere description of suffering does not automatically establish karuṇa rasa, the aesthetic experience of compassion or pathos. It is necessary to investigate how the reader comes to apprehend the character's condition, the arrangement of the scene, rhythm, pauses, expectation, and the transformation of feeling.

It would be improper to prescribe a single “correct” readerly experience of rasa. A reader's familiarity with the language, caste and social position, memories, age, and sensibility can alter the experience. Amid these differences, the critic can establish which affective possibilities the text activates, which scenes or sentences provide their basis, and what alternative readings remain possible.

3.2 Dhvani: The Resonance Beyond What Is Said

Ānandavardhana's theory of dhvani provides a method for exploring meanings suggested by the text beyond its directly denoted meaning. For instance, a “receipt for water tax” hanging at a dried-up river landing is not merely a piece of administrative paper; it may suggest the irony of labour and entitlement. But a critic proposing such a dhvani should

exhibit other contexts in the text, recurring images, and contrary indications, rather than simply projecting a desired politics onto the scene.

Dhvani is not the same as inference in Navya-Nyāya. It can disclose an aesthetic and symbolic possibility; an historical conclusion requires additional documents. “This scene evokes a suggestion of exploitation” and “in a particular year a particular revenue department committed exploitation” are statements bearing different burdens of proof.

3.3 Vakrokti, Rīti, Guṇa, and Alaṅkāra

Kuntaka's account of vakrokti provides grounds for considering unusual oblique configurations of words, sentences, contexts, plots, and entire compositions. A character's unexpected reply, reversed order in a description, the narrator's ironic distance, the length of a sentence, or even silence may generate an effect resembling vakrokti; but not every oddity amounts to artistic achievement. An examination of rīti should attend to ṭheṭhī speech, dialect, scholarly terminology, folk rhythms, differences of linguistic register, and tone appropriate to the occasion. Analysis of guṇa and alaṅkāra should be related to the movement of events or the communication of feeling; merely counting similes and metaphors is not the object.

3.4 The Duality of Propriety and Impropriety

Kṣemendra's thought on aucitya raises questions about the mutual appropriateness of character, language, place and time, purpose, rasa, and the arrangement of scenes. A modern novel, however, may deliberately violate propriety to create dissonance, deviation, irony, or resistance. The method must therefore retain two questions: (a) which arrangements are consistent with the work's internal rules? and (b) which violations of those rules serve a conscious artistic purpose? Criticism must not turn into a traditionalist injunction by calling entrenched restrictions of class, caste, or gender “propriety.”

3.5 The Sensitive Reader, Universalisation, and the Dissenting Reader

To be a sahṛdaya, a responsive reader, is not to agree in advance with the critic's preferred interpretation; it is to possess the critical capacity to enter the text's affective and imaginative situation. A scene of cruelty may generate separate perspectives for the victim, the perpetrator, and the bystander. Discussion of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa (universalisation) must not erase the distinctive historical experience of a person in the name of making it universal. The singularity of the victim's voice and the possibility of a shared understanding must both remain visible.

4. An Examination of Evidence Inspired by Navya-Nyāya

4.1 Inspiration and Limits

Gangeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi considers four pramāṇas, or means of valid cognition: perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), comparison (upamāna), and verbal testimony (śabda). The process of criticism proposed here draws inspiration from the conceptual discipline of that tradition; literary criticism is not being declared literally identical to the Navya-Nyāya doctrine of the Tattvacintāmaṇi. Literary interpretation is not always decisive in the manner of proving a proposition. Preserving this distinction is a precautionary rule.

4.2 Pakṣa, Sādhya, Hetu, and Dṛṣṭānta

The critic should first establish the pakṣa, the subject under consideration: the whole novel, a particular chapter, a narrative strand, or a given passage? Next comes the sādhya: what is to be established? “In Chapter 12 the narrator becomes unreliable” is a proposition capable of examination. Then comes the hetu, the reason: two contradictory accounts of the same event, the narrator's self-interest, a subsequent correction within the text, and so on. The dṛṣṭānta is a second instance employing a comparable compositional device. Without a clearly determined pakṣa, a sweeping judgement such as “this novel is consistently hostile to women” may be unsound.

4.3 Vyāpti, Upādhi, and Fallacies of Reasoning

A critic should not propose the universal relation (vyāpti) that “wherever a first-person narrative occurs, the narrator is unreliable”; innumerable counterexamples would defeat it. A more careful formulation is: “Where a narrator's significant claims systematically conflict with reliable textual evidence available to the reader, a reading in terms of unreliability becomes possible.” Even then, possible qualifications (upādhi) must be examined: the limits of the reader's knowledge, dreams, irony, translation, or shifts in chronology.

Criticism inspired by the Navya-Nyāya tradition should ask whether a reason is established (hetusiddhi): is the supposed indication actually present in the text? Savyabhicāra: does this indication occur in other circumstances too? Viruddha: does the evidence instead support the opposite conclusion? Asiddha: is the basis itself imagined? Bādhita: does later explicit information invalidate an earlier conclusion? The aim of such tests is not to display impressive terminology but to expose faults in reasoning.

4.4 Avacchedaka: Making the Limits of a Claim Explicit

Avacchedaka is useful here as a discipline for delimiting analysis. Before declaring "folk speech is absent from the entire work," it is essential to specify the definition of "folk speech," the distinction between the storyteller's language and characters' dialogue, the manuscript or edition consulted, the sample, and the chapters covered. To say "in the narrator's descriptions in these ten chapters" produces a narrower and more testable claim.

Complex Navya-Nyāya terminology relating to delimited subjects, relations, and properties should not be imposed needlessly upon narrative criticism. The basic rule is simple: about whom is the claim made, concerning which quality, in what relation, and within what temporal limits?

4.5 A Critical Reconfiguration of the Four Pramāṇas

Textual observation analogous to perception: direct inspection of words, sequence, titles, dialogue, and variant readings in manuscripts. This is not literally equivalent to perception in classical Navya-Nyāya; it names primary visual and textual observation in criticism. Inference: a provisional conclusion about narrative technique, character motivation, or implicit ideas drawn from textual evidence. Comparison: a careful analogy with another work, folktale, historical tradition, or epic, in which differences are recorded alongside similarities. Verbal testimony: evaluation of an author's preface, letters, interviews, historical statements, and published sources; the speaker's credibility, context, and interests require independent scrutiny.

Dialogue spoken by a fictional character is not in itself verbal testimony concerning real history, though it may function as reported evidence within the story-world. An author's account of their own intentions may likewise be evidence of those intentions without being the final arbiter of the meanings available in the text. Where sufficient evidence is unavailable, the critic should employ explicit terms of judgement such as "unknown," "possible," "disputed," and "unsupported."

4.6 Pūrvapakṣa, Uttarapakṣa, and Revisable Conclusions

Every significant interpretation should be accompanied by a cogent pūrvapakṣa, or opposing position: how might another critic read the same scene? In the uttarapakṣa, the response, the actual evidence for this alternative reading must be examined. The surviving conclusion should then be assigned an appropriate degree of confidence; "beyond doubt" is warranted only when the kind of evidence permits it. The critic's favoured

ethical standpoint is no substitute for establishing the grounds of an inference.

5. The Critical Adaptation of Videha's Parallel-History Perspective

5.1 The Expansion and Differentiation of Sources

Videha's "parallel-history perspective" accommodates personal letters, songs, genealogical registers, maps, women's domestic writing, local testimony, and oral memory alongside official documents; nevertheless, every source must be questioned as to its nature, date, purpose, and limits. Applied to narratology, this means examining the historical and social position of those whom the novel allows to speak, as well as those whose traces are not fully present. Documentary evidence and fictional invention, however, must not be treated as interchangeable.

5.2 Multiple Voices, Multiple Temporalities, and Multiple Regions

Parallelism is not merely a list of voices present in a single story: the state, cultivators, fishers, women, migrants, children, disadvantaged castes, linguistic borderlands, and communities across national borders. Analysis should ask who makes decisions; who must perform the labour; on whom the consequences fall; whose dialect is designated as standard in the narration; and whose experience is turned into a fixed category called "the folk." Historical time, the cycle of seasons, memory, generational time, river time, and the time of displacement should be distinguished.

5.3 Silence: The Absence of Evidence and Its Narrative Function

The absence of a character may be related to three possibilities: the author's choice, the narrator's limited knowledge, or the structure of power within the fictional world. It would be wrong to select just one without examination. A second level of "silence" comprises what the novel itself leaves unsaid and what the reader infers. A third consists of absence from actual historical archives. These three silences must not be conflated. A fundamental standard of parallel history is that empty spaces should not be filled with invention.

5.4 The Making and Preservation of Archives and the Digital Text

The critic should investigate editions, dates of publication, authorial revisions, changes of script, printing errors, errors in digitised texts, oral adaptations, and the translator's role. The unavailability of material in Maithili's Tirhuta, Devanagari, and other script traditions is not conclusive evidence of its absence from literature. Finding an online copy

on several websites does not establish the existence of three independent sources; all the copies may have originated from a single scan.

5.5 The Ethics of History and the Critic's Self-Examination

A claim by a celebrated mainstream author is not true simply because of that author's prestige. A claim arising from a marginalised account is not true merely because of its neglect. If the critic identifies a lack of social representation, evidence for that assessment must be sought in the text. A more important question is whether a character belonging to a particular group remains merely an entry in a catalogue of atrocities, or possesses desires, initiative, contradictions, and a perspective of their own. Recognising historical injustice must not entail erasing literary creativity.

6. The Full Analytical Scope of Narratology

6.1 Story-World, States, and Eventfulness

At the outset, a map should be prepared of characters, places, relationships, resources, power, and potential crises. An event does not simply mean that "something happened": did a state of affairs change? The relevance, unexpectedness, consequences, irreversibility, and non-repeatability of that change should be examined. A small event—a prohibition on fishing at a river landing—may transform the entire structure of a village; an immense war may occupy a long stretch of description without altering the relationships between characters. The number of events and their narrative significance are two different measures.

6.2 Story Sequence and Narrative Sequence

Wherever possible, construct separate timelines: in what order did events occur in the story-world, and in what order were they narrated to the reader? Identify analepses, anticipations, retellings of the same event, delayed revelations, temporal discrepancies, and concealed disruptions of chronology. Consider the effect of a break in narrative order: mystery, irony, grief, attribution of blame, or the rewriting of history. Rather than merely labelling every retrospective passage a "flashback," explain its cause and effect.

6.3 Duration, Pace, and Pause

A hundred pages devoted to one day in the story-world and two sentences to two decades constitute a meaningful disproportion. Distinguish scene, summary, elaboration, descriptive pause, ellipsis, and narrative acceleration. In assessing density, record separately the number of words, decisive changes, networks of causation, transformations of character, and

emotional depth. More words do not necessarily mean more events; more events do not necessarily mean greater literary excellence. Both equations are mistaken.

6.4 Frequency and the Return of Memory

Identify three tendencies: narrating once an event that occurred once; narrating repeatedly an event that occurred once; and recounting in a single collective statement events that occurred repeatedly. If a labourer, an official, and a young girl recount the memory of the same flood differently, the shared event becomes evidence of plural perspectives. Yet meaningless duplication of the same sentence is not artistic narrative repetition; a purpose is required to distinguish one from the other.

6.5 Narrator, Narrative Level, and Reliability

Who speaks? An external narrator, an internal character, the writer of a letter, a voice in a dream, and the collective voice of a folk song belong to different levels and should be identified separately. “Author” and “narrator” are not the same. Does the narrator participate in the events, or stand outside them? When is the narration undertaken—before, during, or after the events? What is the extent of the narrator's knowledge? Demonstrating unreliability requires contradiction in the telling, limitations of perspective, self-interest, or corrections made within the text; the mere use of the first person is insufficient.

6.6 Focalisation and the Distribution of Knowledge

Alongside “who sees?” ask “who understands?” and “who receives which information?” An event looks different through the eyes of an elite character, through a boatman's embodied experience, and through a child's partial knowledge. Map internal, external, shifting, collective, and uncorroborated focal positions. Discrepancies between what the narrator knows and what a character knows produce irony, mystery, and empathy.

6.7 Character: Not an Inventory of Names but a Network of Actions

Beyond counting characters' social identities, ancestry, or caste, identify their goals, obstacles, choices, capacity for action, contradictions, changing relationships, and development over narrative time. Is a supporting character merely an instrument for the protagonist's development? Does women's labour become visible only during dramatic crises, or also at points where decisions are made? Reducing the complexity of a life to a single moral attribute may indicate weakness in characterisation. Identify a character's silences, actions, and undisclosed desires only where the text provides a basis for doing so.

6.8 Causation, Coincidence, Conflict, and Resolution

Record the causal chain of every decisive event without forcibly imposing a single cause. Natural disasters, government, divisions of labour, family decisions, chance, and memory may interact. A conflict's resolution may be direct, partial, adverse, delayed, or left undecided. Indeterminacy is not automatically a defect of composition; it may also be a device for keeping an artistic question open.

6.9 Space, Rivers, Environment, and the World of Objects

Villages, ponds, houses, cremation grounds, fields, roads, borders, and cities are not mere decoration. Space transforms characters' access, labour, fear, caste divisions, and rights. River water, silt, flooding, aquatic life, water taxes, irrigation, and drainage are at once geography and society. Before making a symbolic assertion such as "the river itself is the narrator," examine what kind of linguistic agency the text grants the river. If a geographical fact is required, obtain an independent map or environmental study.

6.10 Dialogue, Linguistic Registers, and Grammatical Perspective

Who is allowed complete sentences in dialogue, and who appears only in quotation? Do standard Maithili, ṭheṭhī, Angika, Bajjika, regional varieties from Nepal, specialised language, or mixtures of other languages reveal a character's class position, relationships, and power, or do they reinforce stereotypes? Before treating a colloquial form as an "error," examine the author's craft, the character's voice, and the edition in question. Linguistic variation is not merely a diversity of colour; it may be an instrument for distributing narrative authority.

6.11 Consciousness, Dream, Memory, and Interior Dialogue

Distinguish the narrative authority of direct speech, indirect discourse, free indirect discourse, stream of consciousness, fragments of memory, and dreams. It is a mistake either to treat a dream sequence as an actual event in the fictional world without justification, or to regard a deliberate temporal discrepancy as an authorial blunder. Maintain a distance between the truth-value of what a character thinks and what the narrative itself confirms.

6.12 Symbol, Myth, Intertextuality, and Reconfiguration

A narrative may enter into dialogue with the Rāmāyaṇa, the Mahābhārata, Bhāmatī, the Nyāya tradition, local deities, ballads, idioms, folk theatre, and philosophical concepts. The examination of intertextuality must look beyond the mere occurrence of a name to the direction of its transformation, its departure from the original context, its

function in the present setting, and the signs available to readers. The fact that a character is named “Draupadī” does not by itself establish an allegory of the entire Mahābhārata; decisive parallel contexts are needed.

6.13 The Marvellous, the Impossible, and Magical Realism

First identify the rules of the fictional world. The dead speak, a river remembers, time becomes cyclical: these are not necessarily indications of inconsistency on the author's part; they may be alternative rules governing the work's world. The marvellous rasa, supernatural folk belief, an unreliable narrator, a dream, a metaphor, and magical realism should not all be placed in a single category. Examine what changes an impossible event brings about in characters' behaviour and the social structure.

6.14 Structure, Subplots, and Long-Form Narrative

In a very long novel, map the principal narrative strands, subsidiary strands, periods of time, generations, locations, and groups of characters. The number of chapters does not prove literary unity. At what point does a subplot connect with the central conflict? Does it enter into dialogue with another subplot, or merely continue to unfold alongside it? Examine returns, cycles that change as they recur, climaxes, secondary climaxes, extended epilogues, and unresolved strands.

6.15 Rhythm, Imagery, Sound Structure, and Readerly Expectation

Examine the breathing of sentences, the rhythm of dialogue, the pace of description, phonetic recurrence, silence, the pause at the end of a chapter, and how these relate to the expectations created by its title. A brief scene may produce an expansive emotional effect; an extended description may also provoke resistance in the reader. Claims about readerly effects must be substantiated with specific linguistic devices; otherwise avoid universal statements such as “all readers weep.”

6.16 Reader, Genre, Edition, and Medium

A work may take different forms as an oral performance, printed book, electronic text, audiobook, translation, or edition for young readers. Each medium presents different conditions of reception: page divisions, pronunciation, voice, illustrations, chapter numbering, and reader accessibility. How does a translation transmit narrative focalisation, local forms of address, intimations of rasa, and linguistic differences that carry social significance? When comparing editions, make clear which original text is the basis of comparison.

6.17 Social Power and Narratives of Resistance

Read distinctions of caste, class, gender, occupation, religion, embodiment, disability, age, family, migration, and digital access not merely as a list of themes but as narrative actions. Whose desires advance the plot? Whose labour is made visible? Who is given the opportunity to determine an outcome? The storyteller's social commitments may be important, but they cannot replace scrutiny of artistic justice, the causation of events, and the complexity of characters.

6.18 Suffering, Violence, and the Ethics of Representation

Where rape, caste humiliation, suicide, suffering inflicted on children, displacement, violence, or death is depicted, examine the scene's function, the victim's autonomy, the affective burden placed upon the reader, and the risk of sensationalism. A greater quantity of gruesome detail should not automatically be proclaimed "fearless realism." Wherever possible, the critic should attend to the victim's perspective, the consequences, and processes of reconstruction rather than making the victim an object once more. The literary necessity of a disturbing scene and its public responsibility are distinct questions.

7. Three-Tier Examination and an Integrated Critical Formula

Table 1. Questions and Evidence in the Three-Part Method

Basis of examination	Principal question	Admissible evidence	Essential caution
Indian poetics	How does the narrative create rasa, suggestion, and obliqueness?	Language, scenes, symbols, rhythm, and the reader's possible experience	Do not impose a single emotional response upon the reader.
Navya-Nyāya-inspired inquiry	What are the subject, reasons, limits, and counterarguments of a claim?	Textual location, variant readings, counterexamples, and independent references	Do not treat literary inference as mathematical proof.
Parallel history	Whose voice, archive, labour, and silence are decisive?	The network of textual perspectives, provenance of sources, and social context	Do not fill evidentiary absences with invention.

In examining a scene or chapter, the critic should first undertake a compositional examination: event, narrator, focalisation, time, language, symbol, rasa, dhvani, aucitya, and the dynamics of readerly response. This should be followed by an evidentiary examination: the textual grounds of a stated conclusion, the limits of the claim, contrary evidence, sources for historical contexts, and uncertainty. Finally comes a parallel examination: the relationships between centre and margin, voice and silence, archive and memory, region and border, labour and power, and class, caste, and

gender. The findings of all three stages should be recorded separately before a combined judgement is offered.

The proposed critical formula is: adequate evaluation of narrative = analysis of textual construction + conclusions bounded by evidence + multisource sociohistorical examination + reconsideration receptive to opposing arguments. This is not an arithmetic equation; it is a formula indicating the division of critical labour. Its components function as mutual conditions, but no component replaces another. In particular, a high assessment of social representation does not automatically turn poor craftsmanship into excellence, and excellent craftsmanship does not transform a historically false claim into fact.

Behind every decisive critical statement, a "critical ledger" should be maintained: conclusion / textual location / type of evidence / alternative reading / contradictory evidence / level of confidence. Without such a ledger, criticism can become impressive oratory rather than research.

8. Practical Procedure: Sixteen Stages

Table 2. Principal Dimensions of Narrative Analysis

Dimension	Decisive question	Material for examination
Story-world	What is the initial state, and what rules govern it?	Information about the world available in the text
Eventfulness	Which change is decisive?	Prior and subsequent states; consequences
Order	How do story time and narrating time differ?	Two chronologies of events
Duration	Which episode is expanded or compressed?	Relationship of words to elapsed time
Frequency	How often is a single event narrated?	Locations of retelling
Narrator	Who speaks, and who is reliable?	Narratorial assertions and contradictions
Focalisation	Who knows how much?	Distribution of knowledge
Narrative level	How is one story embedded within another?	Letters, dreams, folk narratives
Character network	Who decides, and who bears the consequences?	Goals, acts, and relationships
Conflict and causation	Is an event produced by one cause or many?	Chains of cause and effect
Language and dialogue	Which voice uses which register?	Sentences, dialects, and silences
Rasa and dhvani	How are experience and implied meaning produced?	Scenes and recurring imagery
Vakrokti and aucitya	What purpose do configuration and departures from convention serve?	Linguistic and narrative deviations

Dimension	Decisive question	Material for examination
Space and environment	Does place act causally or serve as decoration?	Movement, resources, geography
Intertextuality	Which mythic or philosophical text is re-read, and how?	Related textual configurations
The marvellous and dream	Under what rules does an impossible occurrence take place?	Coherence within the story-world
Society and history	Whose archives and silences are represented?	Sources, positions, contexts
Reader and medium	How does adaptation change meaning?	Textual variants, audio rendition, translation

Stage 1—Establish the Text. Record the edition, publisher, year, sequence of chapters, language, and pagination used as the basis. Where a revised edition exists, preserve the differences.

Stage 2—Initial Reading of the Whole. Without imposing a synopsis or prior verdict, identify the central tensions, signals of genre, language, strategy of the opening, and nature of the ending.

Stage 3—Basic Counts. Where they can reasonably be measured, count chapters, parts, words, characters, places, proportions of dialogue, historical references, and fragments of memory. Make the distinction between computer-generated counts and human verification explicit.

Stage 4—Event Register. Prepare a separate entry for changes of state, causes, decisive importance, recurrence, and consequences in every chapter.

Stage 5—Dual Timeline. Separate story time from narrative time; mark memory, anticipation, pauses, summary, and repetition.

Stage 6—Map of Narrators and Perspectives. Record who spoke, from which narrative level, who saw, what information was concealed, and when it was disclosed.

Stage 7—Character Network. Map goals, decisions, relationships, social positions, agency, and change.

Stage 8—Examination of Rasa, Dhvani, and Vakrokti. Identify the linguistic foundations of major scenes, the process of affect, suggested meanings, and deliberate violations of aucitya.

Stage 9—Spatial and Environmental Examination. Examine the causal role of place, distribution of resources, weather, animals and birds, rivers, agriculture, cities, and migration.

Stage 10—Examination of Parallel Voices. Ask which groups are affected by decisions made within the central story, whose voices are absent, and through whose mediation each person's words are heard.

Stage 11—Classification of Claims. Mark each decisive conclusion as textual, story-world, interpretative, or external-historical.

Stage 12—Testing of Evidence. Examine page references, doubts, counterexamples, qualifying conditions, external sources, dates of references, and reliability.

Stage 13—Opposing Position. Write at least one strong alternative interpretation. Do not reduce it to a straw man.

Stage 14—Synthesis by Kāṇḍa or Part. Alongside chapter-level conclusions, examine changes across multiple strands, peaks, unresolved questions, and incompleteness.

Stage 15—Overall Assessment. Treat craft, rasa, meaning, social complexity, engagement with history, effects on readers, and limitations under separate headings; do not insist upon a universally accepted numerical score.

Stage 16—Audit and Revision. Record errors, limits of measurement, lack of sources, alternative interpretations, and the date of revision.

9. Rules of Evidence: Twelve Principles for the Critic

Principle 1—Primacy of the Text. For a claim concerning what occurs within the text, seek the first evidence in an identifiable passage of that text.

Principle 2—Distinction of Levels. Keep separate the narrator's statement, a character's belief, the author's intention, and historical truth.

Principle 3—Specification of Limits. Specify the scope of the proposition, chapters, edition, group of characters, and period concerned.

Principle 4—Soundness of Reasons. Verify that the grounds offered by the critic are actually present in the text.

Principle 5—Restraint in Generalisation. Do not formulate a universal literary rule from one or two examples.

Principle 6—Acceptance of Counterexamples. Do not conceal contrary passages; regard them as opportunities to revise the theory.

Principle 7—Consideration of Qualifications. Examine special conditions such as dreams, irony, local dialects, mythic worlds, and unreliable narrators.

Principle 8—Freedom of Rasa. Acknowledge the plurality of affective responses; readers' experiences must not be forced into a statistical measure.

Principle 9—Caution Concerning Silence. Regard silence as a question, not as direct proof of an unknown event.

Principle 10—Evidence-Parity. Examine claims made on behalf of the state, the folk, prestigious authors, Dalit communities, women, authors, and critics alike.

Principle 11—Multiple Causation. A single event may arise from several social, ecological, psychological, and artistic causes.

Principle 12—Revisability. Changing a conclusion when confronted with a new textual variant, document, or strong counterargument is a strength of criticism, not a defeat.

10. Application to a Constructed Illustration

10.1 The Illustration: The Landing and the Receipt

The following scene is a fictional example composed solely for this essay. It must not be taken as a quotation from any published novel: "The pond had dried up. Yet a receipt for water tax was still fluttering in the wind at the landing. Kamli picked up the receipt, but the name written on it was not hers. She said, 'I have paid the price of water; now who will pay the price of the earth?'"

Examination of story: the initial condition is the disappearance of a water resource; the event is Kamli's discovery of the receipt and her raising of a question; the change is that unspoken economic injustice acquires a public voice. Examination of telling: concise description, an object functioning as a sign, and the final question alter the pace of narration. Rasa and dhvani: the contrast between the dried-up pond and the still-valid receipt creates possibilities of compassion and irony; "the price of the earth" suggests labour, entitlement, and ecological loss. Evidence inspired by Navya-Nyāya: "the name was not hers" is a textual fact; "the receipt was forged" is an inference requiring further textual evidence. Parallel examination: who has the authority to issue the receipt, who bears the burden of water tax, and what is changed by the woman's voice? No conclusion concerning any real historical taxation system may be drawn from this invented scene.

10.2 The Opposing Case: Is This Merely a Symbol?

The pūrvapakṣa may maintain that the "dried-up pond" is not a symbol of social justice but merely a scenic detail. Rather than pronouncing a final verdict, the uttarapakṣa would investigate whether receipts, water, taxation, women's labour, land, or entitlement recur elsewhere in the work. If not, the symbolic interpretation remains possible but limited. If several coherent sequences of events and consequences develop these

indications, the proposal gains strength. In this way, the poetics of dhvani and scepticism inspired by Navya-Nyāya become mutually productive.

11. Chapter-by-Chapter and Overall Examination of Long Novels

In examining a novel of several hundred thousand words, indiscriminately piling together every event, original sentence, and interpretation from every chapter makes the criticism itself unreadable. A four-level procedure should therefore be adopted: brief register → synthesis of narrative strands → synthesis of parts → argument concerning the work as a whole. In a chapter register, a factual account of 150–300 words may be sufficient, while chapters decisive in terms of eventfulness or technique may warrant 500–1,000 words of analysis. These figures are merely working suggestions; the limits should be adjusted to the actual complexity of the primary text.

Chapter-by-chapter criticism is not a "summary." It should record each chapter's purpose, its difference from the preceding state of affairs, narrative techniques, major evidence, rasa and dhvani, social location, counterarguments, and relation to the next chapter. An overall assessment is not merely the sum of chapter notes. It separately establishes the relationships among narrative strands, the development of recurring patterns, and the long-term ethical and aesthetic consequences of the story.

The counting method must be explicit when word counts, chapter counts, numbers of characters, or event density are measured. Does "word" mean a count based on spaces, a count after normalising compound forms, or a count following editorial cleaning? Have titles, the table of contents, footnotes, and appendices been counted? If a machine-readable text is unavailable, an estimated number should be described as an "estimate."

For event density, a diagnostic ratio such as "decisive changes of state per 10,000 words" may be useful; it is not, however, a ranking of artistic excellence. Read alongside that ratio the consequences of events, characters' agency, dramatic pauses, and transformations of rasa. One subtle but decisive event may be more powerful than ten ostentatious scenes.

12. Critical Judgement: Measurement, Limits, and Re-examination

Table 3. Four Types of Claim and Their Evidence

Type of claim	Example	Method of verification
Textual	A character spoke a particular sentence.	Check chapter, paragraph, and edition.
Story-world	Did the embankment really break, or was it the narrator's misperception?	Examine narrative level and subsequent confirmation.
Interpretative	The receipt suggests labour exploitation.	Test coherence of imagery and alternative interpretations.
External historical	A water tax was actually levied in a specified year.	Independent records, dates, and source criticism.

If numerical ratings are used in a table, let each criterion receive a score from zero to four for the level of textual support, not for artistic merit: 0 —no evidence; 1—scant or disputed evidence; 2—some examples; 3—several mutually consistent examples; 4—extensive evidence accompanied by an examination of counterarguments. “Not applicable” and “unknown” should remain distinct categories, not zero scores. If scores are weighted, the weights must be published beforehand rather than changed retrospectively to obtain a desired conclusion.

The final judgement should be written in four separate divisions: (a) artistic achievements and deficiencies; (b) strengths and tensions of narrative organisation; (c) the complexity, correspondence with sources, and limits of the social and historical imagination; and (d) the work's new contributions and subjects for future study. All-encompassing judgements such as “the greatest,” “a complete failure,” or “the reality of an entire society” require extraordinary comparative research. Otherwise, precise and bounded judgements are preferable.

The method has limits of its own. Not every dimension of poetic experience can be contained in a form. If the evidentiary language of Navya-Nyāya begins to erase creative uncertainty, its use should be suspended. If parallel history becomes a mechanical “representation score,” characters lose their artistic freedom. Other traditions—folk narrative, feminist and Dalit criticism, postcolonial and environmental approaches, cognitive narratology, and the narratology of the marvellous—may be brought into dialogue as necessary, but no single ideology should control all the meanings of a story.

13. Conclusion: Criticism as a Verifiable and Sensitive Discipline

Evidence-Parity and Parallel Narratology is a proposed research method for the criticism of Maithili narrative. It connects the story-world with the arrangement of narration, aesthetic experience with the discipline of evidence, and literature's centre with voices that are invisible or less often heard. Indian poetics opens up the work's rasa, dhvani, and obliqueness;

analysis inspired by Navya-Nyāya identifies the limits, counterarguments, and errors of inference; the Videha parallel-history perspective makes criticism answerable to unequal archival preservation, silence, and the society disclosed by multiple sources.

What matters among these three foundations is not merely "harmony" but a productive tension. When rasa opens possibilities of implicit meaning, evidentiary examination prevents those possibilities from running away as historical facts. When the testing of evidence narrows the scope of a conclusion, the parallel perspective shows the still-unknown territory beyond it. When history brings social voices into view, narratology asks whether those voices change the structure of the work or merely extend its list of names.

The concluding principle is this: read the story; examine the telling; listen for rasa and dhvani; respect the limits of evidence; investigate the causes of silence; hear the opposing case; and keep open the possibility of testing conclusions anew. Through this discipline, an extensive, chapter-by-chapter, logically coherent, and aesthetically adequate criticism of Maithili narrative literature becomes possible.

Appendix A: Chapter-by-Chapter Critical Assessment Form

In each entry, reproduce the original book's chapter number and title exactly. A title devised by the critic should be identified separately.

Identification: book, edition, part, chapter, page range, word count, reader's circumstances.

State and event: initial state, decisive event, change of state, consequences, unresolved questions.

Narration: story time, narrative order, duration, frequency, narrator, level, focalisation, mystery.

Composition: character network, dialogue, language, space, imagery, rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, aucitya, or deliberate violation of propriety.

Parallel dimensions: power, labour, gender, caste, class, region, environment, silence, marginalised agents, linguistic differences.

Evidence: textual quotation or location, kind of claim, reason, possible qualifications, alternative reading, level of confidence.

Connections: causal relation to the previous chapter, anticipations of what follows, intersections of subplots, transformation of recurring patterns.

Conclusion: artistic achievement; qualified criticism; unresolved question; contribution to the overall thesis.

Appendix B: Decisive Research Questions

1. What knowledge does the opening of the novel conceal from the reader, and what expectations does it establish?

2. Where does the order of events in the story-world differ from the order of their presentation in the narrative?

3. Which events are mentioned repeatedly, and what changes in each retelling?

4. Which scenes occupy many pages although they take little time in the story, and to what purpose?

5. How does an event's decisiveness differ from the number of words devoted to it?

6. Where do the limits of the narrator's knowledge become clear to the reader?

7. Through what linguistic signals are the narrator's voice and the characters' voices differentiated?

8. Which character's decisions have consequences for another character who receives less narrative attention?

9. How does the chain of social causation change when the centre of the story shifts?

10. Which conflicts remain unresolved at the end, and is this irresolution deliberate or inadvertent?

11. How do caste, class, gender, and occupation enter into the decisions that shape the plot?

12. Does folk speech grant a character autonomy, or does it turn that character into a metaphor?

13. Through which arrangements of scenes, rhythms, and suggestions does an effect of rasa become possible?

14. What further evidence within the text supports a claim about dhvani?

15. Is a breach of aucitya a deliberate artistic device or an inconsistency in character construction?

16. Is there a genuine creative reconfiguration behind a mythological name, or merely an allusion?

17. Does a natural scene become a cause of conflict, or remain its background?

18. By which signs can a dream, a memory, and an imagined event be distinguished?

19. Which statement is a textual fact, which is a character's belief, and which is an inference made by the critic?

20. Are independent sources available for the historical claim?

21. What are the three different possible causes of silence?

22. Beyond the social centre, whose experience changes the structure of the narrative?

23. Does translation or audio adaptation alter focalisation or linguistic difference?

24. What is the strongest evidence against the critic's central claim?

25. Does the ending resolve, transform, or complicate the question posed at the beginning?

26. Where do the author's preface and the main text agree or disagree?

27. How substantially would the whole structure change if one subplot were removed?

28. When does the reader's sympathy shift from one character to another?

29. Which conclusions have high confidence, which remain merely possible, and which are unknown?

30. What new experiment in narrative does the work establish in an overall assessment?

Appendix C: Essential Glossary

Story: the reconstructible sequence of the world of events.

Telling: the linguistic or mediated act of presenting a story.

Narrative: the organised composition of story, telling, and reception.

Story-world: the possible world within the work and its governing rules.

Narrative time: the time of narration or its distribution within the text.

Story time: the time of events within the story-world.

Focalisation: the position from which information, experience, and observation are available.

Narrator: the textual agent who tells the story, distinct from the author.

Eventfulness: the narrative significance of a change in a state of affairs.

Narrative level: the hierarchy of the principal narration and stories embedded within it.

Rasa: the aesthetic experience made possible by the affective organisation of a work.

Dhvani: meaning suggested beyond the directly expressed sense of words.

Vakrokti: artistic obliqueness or an unexpected linguistic configuration.

Rīti: the characteristics of stylistic formation and word choice.

Aucitya: the appropriateness of context, character, language, and artistic objective to one another.

Pakṣa: the specified subject of critical consideration.

Sādhya: the quality or conclusion proposed for establishment.

Hetu: the reason or indication offered in support of a conclusion.

Vyāpti: the general relationship that enables inference; caution is needed in literary applications.

Upādhi: a special condition that restricts a general inference.

Avacchedaka: a subtle delimiting distinction determining the semantic scope of a claim.

Pūrvapakṣa: a competent presentation of a rival interpretation.

Uttarapakṣa: a critical response supported by evidence.

Textual fact: material directly available in the text.

Story-world fact: an event established or contested within the work.

Interpretative claim: a disputable proposal about meaning prompted by the text.

External historical claim: a verifiable statement about the world beyond the work.

Parallel perspective: the interrelated examination of diverse sources, positions of power, temporalities, and voices.

Analysis of silence: inquiry into the causes of absent voices or evidence.

Evidence-parity: equal commitment to the explicit examination of all claims, while remaining alert to inequalities in the circumstances of their sources.

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PART II

Streams of Narrative, Landings of Time

A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles: A Complete Narratological Study of 301 Critical Sections

Primary work: A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles — the complete Maithili trilogy.

Original novelist: Gajendra Thakur.

Scope of criticism: 301 critical sections, corresponding to Original Chapters −100 through 200.

Throughout this critical work, events within the narrative are distinguished from their interpretation. Accusations, doubts, or statements made by characters within the novel are not treated as externally verified history or as findings of legal guilt.

The final chapter examines in detail the difference between incongruities deliberately fashioned as part of the narrative and independent inconsistencies within the text.

Preface: How to Read the Narrative

This comprehensive study is concerned with the evaluation of narrative: who speaks, through whose perspective events are presented, how time moves, which objects carry memory into later scenes, and what kinds of judgement the many testimonies within the narrative demand of the reader. Debts inherited from the prehistory, the life of rivers and ponds, drama and folk song, legal records, digital voices, and names within households all form distinct levels of a single narrative world.

Each critical section relates to a chapter of the original work. The first critical section addresses Original Chapter −100, the 101st addresses Chapter 0, and the 301st addresses Chapter 200. Where the original opens several possibilities, the criticism preserves their incompleteness; where textual inconsistencies occur, it does not conceal them beneath invented connections.

The book's extended concluding discussion examines when incongruity serves as a device of narrative technique, and when it remains a matter for collation of the text before publication.

Critical Section 1 | Original Chapter −100 — The Conch and Silver

The First Opening: From the Misapprehension of an Object to the Question of Communal Truth

The novel opens its prehistory not with an ordinary historical account but with the dramatic immediacy of a question. Garh Narikel, Channa Gachhi, the peepal tree, the paired ponds, and Burhba appear together in an exceptionally compressed introduction. The narrator declares that the village's memory has lived for twelve hundred years in the roots of a tree. The immediate purpose of this account is not to measure a place realistically, but to establish a peculiar rule governing the duration of memory and the possibility of collective witness.

The essence of the introductory saying is: "Not everything that glitters is silver, and not every name is a body." Its first half translates the philosophical illustration of nacre and silver into the idiom of popular speech; its second half opens the distinction between name, body, and social existence. Placed together, these statements alert the reader that the problem of deceptive perception will return as an ethical problem of identity, archives, death, and testimony. Yet this connection, announced in advance, is only a literary undertaking: whether it is realised in practice in the ensuing chapters requires independent scrutiny.

The narrator's opening carries the reader back to a debating hall "twelve hundred years ago." The contemporary digital "web of screens" and the ancient conch-and-silver dispute enter the same paragraph. Consequently, the beginning contains both retrospective illumination and anticipation of the future. Temporal distance is not merely a background detail here; it becomes a condition under which the reader must accept the novel's immense historical scale.

Mapping Actual Events: Distinguishing Scenes from Changes in Knowledge

The account of the old village and Burhba is presented in the introductory passage as something "people say"; the truth of Burhba's origins is not shown taking place directly before the reader. The first outward action of the play is a servant's placement of a lamp, a rope, and a conch. The stage-manager displays these objects, establishes the problem of the drama, and sings a song. The disparity between this restricted stage action and the considerable elaboration of ideas is the chapter's fundamental compositional choice.

In the first act, the Objector questions the necessity of investigating the self; the response distinguishes certainty that "I" exist from knowledge of the nature of that "I." The second act presents the Naiyāyika account of anyathākhyāti, which Vācaspati then subjects to objections. The third examines the Prābhākara theory of akhyāti. The fourth makes the decisive assertion in favour of anirvacanīyakhyāti. In the epilogue the stage-manager lifts the conch and places it down again. Thus the object remains virtually unchanged onstage, while claims about its interpretation have been transformed.

The outward dramatic action in this sequence is slight. Claims to the possession of truth, the opponent's inferences, and the silence of the assembly become the principal events of change. The reader must sustain the expected dramatic tension across four acts largely through intellectual opposition.

A Concise Table of Events and Argumentative Transformations

Division of the text	Textually established act or dispute	Narratological classification
Opening	The prior history of Garh Narikel and Burhba	Background and reported history; not an immediate stage event
Stage setting	A servant sets down a conch, cord, and lamp	Placement of visible objects as grounds for debate
Act I	A question about knowledge and inquiry concerning the "I"	The epistemological problem becomes explicit
Act II	The Naiyāyika's account of anyathākhyāti and the reply	Counterposition and rebuttal
Act III	The Prābhākara's akhyāti and the reply	The limits of another opposing position are presented
Act IV	The thesis of anirvacanīyatā is advanced	A change of understanding in the doctrinal position
Epilogue	The stage-manager lifts and replaces the conch	The object remains unchanged; the spectator's understanding changes
Bhāmatī group	A collection of examples and scriptural sayings	Expository analysis, not a distinct story event

Narrator, Focalisation, and Narrative Levels

In the chapter's first four paragraphs, an extensively informed third-person narrative voice brings together the village's historical time, Burhba's folkloric identity, and the crisis to come. This voice has broad narrative authority, yet it does not reach a definite verdict on Burhba's actual existence. Formulations of the "some say" kind maintain a distance between popular belief and the truth of the narrated world. The account of "twelve hundred years" is a claim of collective memory, not verified historiography.

Within the debating hall, the narrative level changes. The stage-manager addresses the audience directly and urges it to look at the rope and conch. The Objector, Vācaspati, the Naiyāyika, and the Prābhākara then speak from within their respective epistemic limits. "Who sees?" and "Who speaks?" are therefore no longer the same question. The spectator sees the rope or conch on the stage; the person under the illusion exists only within the illustrative example; and the disputants explain that person's experience. The silver described by the Naiyāyika is not actually present onstage: it is the disputed object of philosophical argument.

At the end, in the section entitled "Bhāmatī—Stories, Narratives, Illustrations, and Quotations," the stage-manager once more assumes the role of compiler and instructor. After the living voices of the dramatic characters, the text becomes an extended succession of traditional examples and scriptural utterances. This shift in narrative level matters: the plurality of speaking voices in the debate is ultimately brought under the authority of a single expositor. Both the achievement of polyphonic narration and the limitation imposed by a single controlling voice become perceptible here.

Time, Duration, Repetition, and Narrative Distance

The opening paragraphs compress almost twelve hundred years; the presentation of one evening in the debating hall extends across numerous pages. The ratio between the longue durée of history and the expansion of the immediate debate offers an appropriate instance for examining the distinction between story-duration and discourse-duration as discussed by Gérard Genette. The negative numbering of "Chapter –100" is itself a paratextual temporal signal. It is not the actual date of an event but a structural arrangement that ushers the reader into a prolonged prehistory.

The illusion involving the conch recurs at three levels: as the formula of the saying, as the rhythm of a song, and as the subject of dramatic reasoning. Repetition does not mean the mere return of identical words. In the saying the image becomes a moral conclusion; in the song, a communal voice; in the dialogue, an analysable problem. Nevertheless, the extensive accumulation of further examples after the fourth act has ended slows the narrative pace. The issue is to distinguish meaningful recurrence from the burden of redundancy.

Initially the narrator establishes a distance of wonder around Burhba; later the interpretation of the philosophical debate is supplied at very close quarters. The reader enjoys greater freedom of independent inference in the initial uncertainty than in the final exposition. Such a narrowing of distance cannot simply be called a defect: clarity matters in a text built

around intellectual instruction. Yet the questioning nature of the novel also makes it important to preserve some indeterminacy.

Characters, Dialogue, Silence, and Social Representation

Vācaspati Miśra is the chapter's central interpretative authority. The Objector introduces an ethics of doubt, since the theory could not be unfolded without his questions. The different philosophical positions of the Naiyāyika and the Prābhākara give them distinct voices, although their human individuality remains relatively slight. They are present to perform argumentative functions, not with their own social lives, memories, or independent desires oriented toward the future. The distinction between a "character" and a "position in an argument" becomes especially clear.

The assembly's "slight laughter" and the "silence" at the second act's conclusion serve as stage signs of the opposing doctrine's social defeat. They successfully impart movement to the debate, but also raise the question of equality between disputants: why does the opposing position not receive the final word before the solution favoured by the author? The Naiyāyika's answer is rapidly made to seem weak, and the Prābhākara does not receive adequate room to develop his objection in full. Such dramatic efficacy is not final philosophical proof.

The stage-manager, Vācaspati, and all the declared disputants are male voices. The opening promises an immense field of communal memory, but the debating hall contains no independent counterargument by a woman, labourer, artisan, or service worker. The servant places the conch and lamp but does not speak. This absence is a social limitation of the first chapter. It would be inappropriate, however, to infer from it the absence of these communities throughout the novel. The relevant question is whether the subsequent collective narrative expands this restricted assembly of knowledge.

The Symbolic System: Conch, Rope, Lamp, Water, and Name

The conch is the chapter's actual theatrical object. It is set beside the entrance, seen by lamplight, lifted in the epilogue, and replaced. Without this tangible scenic object, the dispute over illusion would remain a collection of technical terms. The drama moves the conch's stability and its interpretation's instability in contrary directions: the object remains one, while claims made about it are multiple.

Mistaking a rope for a snake embodies fear; mistaking the conch for silver embodies desire or expectation. These examples have different consequences for bodily perception: in one, the body withdraws; in the other, the hand reaches forward. The text does not develop this distinction

at length, but it may establish different ethical trajectories for the systems of fear and networks of greed in the ensuing novel. In this chapter, that remains a possibility, to be confirmed or contradicted only in later chapters.

The lamp might have become a simple emblem of knowledge's triumph. The play's subtlety, however, lies in the fact that increasing illumination makes the conch clearer without immediately ending the social dispute over knowledge. Visual clarity and agreement over interpretation are distinct processes. "Name" provides an axis broader than the conch: the original saying introduces the distinction between body and name, while Burhba's story juxtaposes the crocodile's devouring of bodies and the enduring testimony of names. Water is not yet a major event of flooding, but a sign of folk memory and the purported beginnings of water burial.

The Intertext of Indian Philosophy: Classical Sources and Creative Transformation

The chapter explicitly declares that it follows the argumentative movement of the initial discussion of adhyāsa in Vācaspati Miśra's Bhāmatī. The experience of "I," bodily change, dreaming and waking, anyathākhyāti, akhyāti, and anirvacanīyakhyāti distribute a classical philosophical dispute among a succession of theatrical characters. Through this dramatic transformation, the opponent becomes a speaking human being; a doctrine is no longer merely a technical designation.

The relationship between the original philosophy and its staged arguments must nevertheless be determined with care. The play itself states that "the Naiyāyika, the Prābhākara, and the Objector are composite characters." Their dialogue is therefore not a verified verbatim exchange between the historical Vācaspati and an actual Naiyāyika or Prābhākara. Critical discussion must consistently preserve the boundary between disputes within a philosophical tradition and character-based scenes composed by the author.

After the discussion of Bhāmatī, the group of examples includes the crystal and the hibiscus, the road to Gandhāra, the two birds, nacre and silver, a divine body in a dream, a person wearing earrings, and numerous scriptural utterances. The list generates extensive echoes of philosophical culture, but the exact source text, location, textual variants, and translation of each maxim or quotation require separate research. Several lines are incorporated into extended sequences as aphorisms; without establishing their sources, it would be inappropriate to present all of them as verbatim citations from any one primary work.

An Examination of Argument: Subject, Reason, Delimitation, and Possible Fallacies

The central question in the chapter is "What is illusion?" A conch is directly seen, cognition of silver arises, and subsequent correction defeats that cognition. The subject of inquiry is an illusory experience; the disputed property is its ontological status. The Nyāya position offers an account involving the displacement or misattribution of an object of cognition. The Prābhākara view points to the failure to discriminate between perception and memory. The Advaita position establishes the indefinability of the experience. This is the internal structure of the play's argument, not a definitive reconstruction of the entire history of the schools concerned.

Vācaspati asks the Naiyāyika what evidence establishes the appearance of silver "here" when the silver is elsewhere. The pertinent critical question is whether the opponent's thesis, as initially defined, is the same thesis that the response subsequently refutes. Unless the object of knowledge, the form of cognition, the relation to memory, and sensory defect are carefully distinguished, it becomes easy to defeat a simplified opponent. A possible limiting condition—defective illumination or an association produced by memory—must be examined before a general conclusion is accepted.

In the response to the Prābhākara, the problem of blending two cognitions is raised; Vācaspati asks whether the blending is itself cognition or merely inadvertence. As a compositional objection, this is effective. Yet victory within the narrative of a debate and final proof in epistemology are not the same thing. The extension from the illustration to the claim that "the world, too, resembles the silver of the conch" moves from a particular example to an ontology of the world as a whole. Whether the common property underlying the analogy is sufficient must be examined independently. In the terminology of Navya-Nyāya, the pervasion (vyāpti) and delimiting conditions (avacchedaka) of this extension require greater precision.

For this purpose Navya-Nyāya terminology provides a useful critical measure; it does not establish that the play is itself a later Navya-Nyāya treatise. Where insufficient evidence leaves the extension of a thesis undecided, criticism should say not "proved," but "held to have been established by the play's principal theorist."

Rasa, Dhvani, Appropriateness, and the Experience of the Responsive Reader

Read together, the introductory folk song and the scene of the conch produce a suggestion (dhvani) of perceptual deception: the ordinary trust placed in glitter, form, and name is brought into crisis. Wonder and curiosity are the initial enduring dispositions; a minor moment of humour appears in the assembly's laughter at an objection associated with the Nyāya position. The chapter's dominant experience, however, is not the full realisation of the pathetic sentiment (karuṇa-rasa), but the demand for reflection generated by argument. The village's water burial and Burhba's mystery plant the seeds of pathos; they do not yet constitute a fully developed scene of suffering.

The question of aucitya, or artistic appropriateness, arises particularly in two places. First, the folk song joins the linguistic world of the philosophical assembly to the proverb of the village, lending appropriateness to the collective speech of Garh Narikel. Second, once the dialogue ends, a very extended succession of Upaniṣadic examples and metaphysical statements begins. For readers expecting continuity of dramatic form, this uniformly expository section burdens dramatic appropriateness.

The reader's position repeatedly shifts: first a listener in the village, then a spectator in the assembly, then an examiner of the disputants' arguments, and finally a student of collected sayings. This layered readership is a significant achievement. Yet reading contracts that change so rapidly will not be equally accessible to every reader.

Contradictions, Repetitions, and an Impartial Assessment of Achievement

The chapter's first major achievement is to turn a philosophical illustration into a material object of theatre. The darkness of the room, the lamplight, the conch beside the entrance, and the spectator's acts of looking give visual form to an error of cognition. A second achievement is the establishment of an initial epistemic problem for the later conflicts over names, evidence, and digital networks. A third is the structural audacity of bringing the cadence of a folk saying, dramatic dialogue, and scriptural exempla into one chapter.

The limits of these achievements are equally evident. In many passages, the disputants remain representatives of doctrines; their lived purposes and capacity for independent debate are restricted. The opponent's silence and the assembly's laughter take the place of intellectual adjudication. The excessive development of examples after the four-act drama has reached its

epilogue weakens the force of the dramatic ending already achieved. The promise of village labour and social suffering does not find an opportunity to speak in the immediate setting of the debate.

The presentation of philosophy is linguistically sophisticated in many places; nevertheless, the density of metaphysical formulations may halt the narrative flow for general readers. This difficulty cannot simply be dismissed as the reader's inadequacy, for the novel itself claims to address multiple communities. The question is whether the narrative creates sufficient bridges through which its knowledge can circulate in society.

The final critical verdict on Chapter –100 is limited. It succeeds as an intellectual prologue, particularly because of its potential to connect the problem of illusion with the ethical right to a name; as a self-contained story driven by events, however, its tension is uneven. The unfolding of ideas occupies more space than the story's action. The appropriateness of this proportion within the trilogy can be established only after comparison with the social events of the subsequent chapters.

Relation to the Trilogy as a Whole: A Test Still to Be Undertaken

This opening chapter simultaneously establishes a twelve-hundred-year narrative horizon, Burhba's role as witness, the opposition between name and body, the potential significance of water burial, and the motif of modern screen-based networks. The presence of these signals does not mean that the whole novel has fulfilled them successfully. Analyses beginning with Chapter –99 must examine how the initial intellectual propositions concerning self, memory, and evidence become actions in a world of women's testimony, the invisibility of labour, aquatic environments, and digital crime.

This will be the decisive discipline of criticism: literary significance must be assessed not by word count, abundance of classical terminology, or ambition alone, but by a combined examination of changes actually enacted in the text, the internal coherence of its imagined world, the fair presentation of opposing voices, and the reader's experience. Chapter –100 poses the questions of this inquiry; their answers must remain open until the final assessment.

Critical Section 2 | Original Chapter −99 — The Debate on the Establishment of the Self

The Testimony of "I": A Decisive Shift in the Question from the Previous Chapter

In "The Conch and Silver," the fundamental question of identification was whether the object seen and the meaning attributed to it were one and the same. "The Debate on the Establishment of the Self" transfers this uncertainty from the object to the existence of the knower. The narrative sequence of the philosophical undertaking is significant: if perception could be mistaken in the previous chapter, the next asks who undergoes the experience of being mistaken. The succession of these two chapters is not a casual embellishment with philosophy but an attempt to establish an initial intellectual sequence involving identity, evidence, and witness. Yet the narrative validity of this sequence can be fully demonstrated only after its relationship to the rights of witnesses and of names has been examined in the subsequent social chapters.

The opening village proverb, "The witness of the one who says 'I' is their own breath," sets the self's testimony against testimony from outside. "Breath" is the immediately perceptible rhythm of the body, while the play's argument seeks to establish a continuous self distinct from that rhythm. The proverb's compression brings these two different things into an apparently natural proximity within experience. This is an aesthetic achievement, but also an intellectual difficulty: the continuity of breathing does not itself prove the permanence of an incorporeal self. Unless this distinction is preserved, a figure drawn from popular speech may secure premature assent to a conclusion that the argument has yet to substantiate.

The first chapter's conch, established as an object onstage, is replaced here by a new group of theatrical objects: a lamp burning in daylight, a royal debating hall, and a water-clock measuring time. The movement from the existence of the conch to the existence of the self is not merely an exchange of topics; it is a change in the standard of evidence. To examine how a philosophical problem becomes an act within a story, one must read the drama, the classical anecdotes, and the collection of maxims in this chapter as distinct forms.

The World of the Drama and the Narrator's Second-Level Frame

At its beginning, the chapter defines its own form: an original dramatic composition divided into a prologue, four acts, and an epilogue. The stage-manager makes this formal declaration a limit on claims to historical authenticity rather than a mere theatrical convention. His explicit

statement, “What you are going to hear is not history,” is the most important denial of documentary authority in the chapter. The separation of Udayana as a historical person from his opponent Kṣaṇabhadra as a fictional composite protects the reader from being offered an invented direct conversation under the guise of historical fact.

The acknowledged artificiality of the drama makes its narrative levels clear: the stage-manager's presentation within the novel's large fictional world; the dialogue of the royal assembly within that presentation; and the examples of seeds, pots, dreams, mangoes, stones, and lamps within the dialogue. An event in an illustrative example is neither an attested historical event nor something that takes place directly on the stage. Erasing these differences would immediately distort any calculation of event density. It would likewise be inaccurate to treat the stage-manager's first-person declaration and the direct speech of Udayana and Kṣaṇabhadra as utterances by a single omniscient narrator.

A lamp burns in the daytime in the royal hall, and the water-clock fixes the limits of each speaker's time. Although the lamp is a textual sign, it returns later in the reasoning about knowledge's self-illumination. The water-clock is the more decisive object: disputants' arguments could continue indefinitely, but their public opportunity to argue is finite. At the outset, the stage-manager directs that no one should claim victory before the opponent has received the full allotted time. This formal equality becomes a critical standard against which one can subsequently examine how much freedom of reasoning the opponent actually receives.

An Event Map of Four Acts: Changes of State and Intellectual Turning Points

The following is not an exact numerical count of events. At the level of visible stage action, the stage-manager appears, the water-clock begins to run, Kṣaṇabhadra takes the opponent's seat, the lamp is adjusted, Udayana descends from his raised seat in the third act to stand at an equal level, and at the end Kṣaṇabhadra respectfully folds his hands and departs. Amid this limited external action, the principal dramatic event is a transformation in intellectual positions.

In Act I, the broad claim of momentariness progresses towards questions of the potentiality of a seed and the continuity of causes. Act II moves from the apparent externality of dreams to the shared world of a simultaneously perceived pot and mutually intelligible conversation. Act III places the question of a knower persisting across time at its centre, drawing upon the alleged grammatical fiction of “I,” agency, the body, and memory. Act IV moves from an intellectual concession concerning the self to practical objections about suffering and liberation. The

conclusion leaves the elaborate dispute over the proof of God unresolved. This sequence is more than an extended table of subjects: the doubt at the end of each act gives the next act its point of departure.

A Working Table of Textually Attested Events and Changes

Narrative division	Change occurring in the original text	Critical classification
Prologue	The disputation opens with rules; Kṣaṇabhadra's invented identity is specified	Dramatic procedure and evidentiary caution
Act I	The universal claim of momentariness is challenged through causal capacity and the persistence of the seed	Change of position within an argument
Act II	The dream example expands into questions about a shared pot and the reciprocity of hearers	Debate over a shared world of knowledge
Act III	Udayana leaves his seat; a pupil challenges the account of memory; ālaya-vijñāna is mentioned	Equality on stage and a decisive dispute over memory
Act IV	Kṣaṇabhadra accepts the self, but asks about suffering, liberation, and the limits of proving God	Partial acceptance followed by further questions
Epilogue	Instead of a definitive doctrine, the stage-manager proposes sharpening the question as a standard	Self-reflexive, open ending
Collection of illustrations and maxims	Elephant, infant, housewife, weaver, snakebite, and many sayings are gathered	Reworking of learned quotations, not immediate dramatic action

Act I: The Unestablished Pervasion Between Existence and Momentariness

Kṣaṇabhadra's principal proposition is that whatever exists is momentary; the destruction of a pot is offered as an example comparable to the destruction of the self. Udayana immediately asks where the necessary pervasion (vyāpti) between "being existent" and "lasting only a moment" has been established. This offers a genuine opportunity for a test consonant with Navya-Nyāya within the text. The subject (pakṣa) is the self, the property to be established (sādhya) is momentariness, the proposed reason (hetu) is existence, and the proposed pervasion is "whatever exists is momentary." A pot breaks at some point, but that example alone does not yield a rule that every existent thing is destroyed at every moment. Udayana's objection is aimed at this unjustified extension of the example.

Criticism, nevertheless, cannot automatically accept Udayana's conclusion as the final judgement of philosophy. A philosophical defender of momentariness could provide an independent explanation of the distinction between a pot's practical continuity and its ultimate destruction. In the play Kṣaṇabhadra counters with images of a succession of potentialities and a relay of torches. It is not sufficient to dismiss this

counterargument entirely as metaphor. The disputed link is how causal regularity between one instant and the next can be understood without a permanent substance. Udayana's response by way of an image is a pointed challenge, but not independent proof of the historical refutation of every Buddhist theory of momentariness.

The seed, water, heat, soil, and the waiting imposed by seasons join philosophical inference to the agricultural experience of Mithila. For the cultivator, the difference between "the seed has not yet sprouted" and "the seed possesses the capacity to sprout" is profoundly practical. The story makes an argument intelligible through this experience. Yet the practical persistence of a seed and the metaphysical persistence of the self are not properties with identical delimiting conditions. Transferring a conclusion about the seed to the self requires an additional reason. The work carries the reader across this unproved extension by the force of dramatic assurance; that is one of its limitations.

Act II: Dream, the Shared Pot, and the Dialogic Irony of Disputation

The second act is entitled "The Hall of Mirrors." Kṣaṇabhadra begins with the dream garden: a scene that seems to be outside the dreamer can arise even without a corresponding external object. The example distinguishes the apparent "externality" of cognition from the actual external existence of its object. Udayana offers two responses: the practical difference between dreaming and waking, and the agreement among several people's tests of the weight, shape, and sound of one pot. In this transition from an individual's experience to public agreement, the drama's epistemology assumes a social form.

The most effective theatrical question is on what grounds Kṣaṇabhadra, if he accepts only his own stream of cognition, addresses Udayana as another person. The form of disputation itself becomes an object of demonstration. This is more than a philosophical argument: in an actual assembly two people listen to each other's replies and modify their views, so the existence of an audience and interlocutors is a theatrical expectation of dialogue. An important counterposition remains, however: could mutual experience be explained solely through causal relations among the experiences of distinct minds? The play does not investigate this possibility fully and independently.

Kṣaṇabhadra says, "I accept the breaking of this pillar," before moving to the next question. This is a narrative moment of genuine, partial defeat for the opponent. Yet combining different opposing positions within one fictional character creates a risk: dream theory, the denial of external objects, and universal momentariness may appear to be necessary branches of a single, uniform philosophical doctrine. The stage-manager's initial

disclosure that the character is composite recognises this difficulty candidly; the reader must likewise refrain from treating this mixed voice as historically homogeneous.

Act III: The Knower, Grammar, and the Bridge of Memory

At the beginning of the third act, Udayana steps down from the teacher's elevated seat and stands level with Kṣaṇabhadra. Formal equality, previously indicated by the rules governing turns, now receives visual confirmation. The body's language onstage alters the authority of argument: what is declared decisive is the evidence supplied in question and answer, not personal prestige. The effectiveness of this emblem, however, depends on how many opposing possibilities remain alive in the ensuing dialogue.

Udayana raises the problem of the agent through the utterances "I am tired" and "I understood." Kṣaṇabhadra responds with the counterexample of an agentless expression such as "It is raining." Here the opponent is not a feeble, silent figure. He raises a genuine question about the difference between grammar and ontology. Udayana acknowledges the appropriateness of the reply before insisting on the need to distinguish an act of knowing from the possession of agency. This is among the finest disputational moments in the chapter precisely because the opponent is first allowed to make his point in full.

Yet the general proposition that knowledge is an act and that every act necessarily requires a separate agent itself demands examination as a pervasion free of limiting conditions. Accepting the counterexample of rain and setting it aside does not, by itself, prove a universal rule of agency. A rigorous criticism must regard the matter as a partial demonstration: the play strengthens the alternative of a knower without conclusively proving that this is the sole logical necessity.

The disciple's question—"Master, may I ask something that troubles me?"—introduces one of the most effective human changes in the dialogue. Rather than a public antagonist, a curious member of the teacher's own side now raises the inadequacy of the example. Through the present recollection of a mango tasted in childhood, Udayana constructs a temporal bridge within the life of one person. Narratologically, this is the chapter's central "internal event": argument becomes a story of embodied memory. Yet memory, personal identity, and an enduring self must not be accepted in one uninterrupted inference; possibilities involving the causal chain of remembering, false memories, and the social formation of memory require examination.

Kṣaṇabhadra invokes ālaya-vijñāna. Udayana treats its concealed continuity as approaching the self accepted by his own school. It would be

premature to declare these concepts metaphysically synonymous: the explanatory purpose of continuity may differ from the proposition that an enduring self-substance exists. Within the play this is a moment of dramatic convergence; at the level of philosophical history it is not a documentary record of final agreement among historical schools. Preserving this distinction is a condition of responsible criticism.

Act IV: From the Debate over Evidence to Suffering, Liberation, and the Unanswered Question of God

In the fourth act Kṣaṇabhadra introduces an unexpected turn: let it be conceded that the self exists, but why is there suffering, and how can liberation actually become possible? His question—"Have you won for me a self worth keeping?"—subjects philosophical victory to a practical ethical test. Human suffering enters after theoretical assertion. Narratologically, this is the sharpest turn in the chapter: the answer sufficient for the teacher's earlier question is not equally sufficient for the character's purposes in life.

Udayana replies that liberation becomes intelligible because there is a continuous subject across the bondage of illusion and its correction. Kṣaṇabhadra's actual question, however—an established means of reducing suffering and the experiential or ethical criteria of liberation—remains incompletely resolved. The play does not conceal this incompleteness. The subsequent question raises the necessity of God's existence, and Udayana himself acknowledges the limitation of time. Such incompletion admits two readings: as a modest and open philosophical space, or as an expedient postponement of a difficulty that the composition has not resolved.

Kṣaṇabhadra's final respectful departure is not necessarily a picture of defeat; the stage directions expressly indicate that he does not feel entirely vanquished. The opponent does not become wholly passive but returns to the questions that remain. The stage-manager's epilogue likewise accepts that the adversary will return in future ages with new instruments. A self-conscious sense of doubt therefore survives the verbal victory of the fourth act. This internal contradiction is not merely a fault: taken seriously by the reader, it can make unfinished inquiry the drama's central achievement.

Narrative Time, Duration of Presentation, Silence, and Recurrence

The principal drama occurs within the limited time of a debating assembly. From beginning to end, the water-clock measures its temporal bounds. The original, however, provides no definitive number of hours or minutes, so no imaginary duration should be supplied. Numerous long passages of dialogue expand experienced time, while the characters' rising,

falling silent, folding their hands, and lowering the lamp occur within brief stage moments. The distinction between "expanded dialogic scene" and "illustrative pause" is especially useful for analysing duration.

The silences do not all mean the same thing. Kṣaṇabhadra's pause in the first act signals the renewal of thought; the "long silence" of the second brings the public pressure of a changed position into the assembly; the final gesture of respect in the fourth is a language of ethical closure. Members of the assembly contribute little independent reasoning, chiefly furnishing the social sound of whispers and agreement. This produces, on the one hand, a communal effect in the philosophical drama; on the other, the danger that a signal of majority agreement may replace proof.

The folk song's sense of "I-ness" reappears in the play's central question of "I." Seeds, pots, lamps, and rivers recur in different contexts, but their narrative functions are not identical. The river first figures a succession of instants, then becomes part of the dispute about waves and stability; the pot is evidence of a shared perceptible world; the lamp becomes an image in the debate about self-awareness and the opposing position. A returning symbol that acquires fresh meaning must be distinguished from an instruction that is merely repeated.

From Classical Text to Modern Maithili Drama: The Limits of Intertextuality

After the four acts, the text adds a note declaring that the play follows the four major movements of Udayana's Ātmatattvaviveka and that Kṣaṇabhadra is a fictional composite of positions associated with Dharmakīrti, Ratnakīrti, Jñānaśrī, and others. This is an explicit declaration of intended intertextuality. It does not imply that every simile, sentence, or scholastic conclusion in the play has been reproduced verbatim from the Sanskrit original. Without collating the passage against an identified Sanskrit edition, such a self-description should not be treated as equivalent to historical textual evidence.

The Bhāmatī-centred dispute about illusion in Chapter –100 and the Ātmatattvaviveka-centred establishment of the self in Chapter –99 form a highly significant arrangement. The first investigates the limits of confidence in the object of knowledge; the second searches for the continuity of the knowing subject. These chapters do not simply fuse Vedic and Buddhist, or Advaita and Nyāya, doctrines. They bring different structures of proof and different fundamental questions into proximity with the novel's larger problems of witness and memory. If distinctive doctrines are carelessly joined, the philosophical plurality of the narrative will become an artificial unity in the criticism.

The value of dramatic adaptation is not only that it preserves ideas from a source: it also renders philosophical commentary as readable scenes of questioning, perplexity, hesitation, relinquishment of authority, and dissatisfaction. Udayana's descent from the teacher's seat in Act III is the adaptation's most concrete success. Certain extended statements, however, sound more like lectures than stage conversation, particularly when Udayana supplies lengthy doctrinal explanations instead of awaiting a response. This imbalance among the voices at times unsettles the relation between story and scholastic discourse.

The Distinct Literary Nature of the Examples Following the Dramatic Epilogue

Once the drama has ended with its epilogue, a separate part appears within the chapter, entitled "Stories, Illustrations, and Quotations from Ātmatattvaviveka." Its many items include the fool's elephant, a housewife with lentils in her mouth, a blue-and-white pigeon, a newborn child, a ritual healer and a victim of snakebite, a cat, a weaver, atoms likened to Raktabīja, smoke in a dream, milkless teats on a goat's neck, and seeds fallen in a field. These are not fresh scenes enacted in the preceding royal assembly. They are narrative exempla and conceptual signs gathered by the stage-manager. In delimiting the source, it is appropriate to call this an embedded collection within Chapter –99, not an independent chapter of the original or a general appendix situated after the trilogy.

The diversity of the examples is striking. The uncertain identification of an elephant reveals imaginative overdetermination in knowledge; smoke in a dream suggests the dependence of inference on circumstances; and seeds scattered in a field illustrate the danger of overly broad causal generalisation. But the characters of the preceding drama do not return to question these examples. The adversarial method of debate becomes a one-sided collection. The reader's store of knowledge expands, but narrative tension does not increase correspondingly. This transformation may also represent a deliberate archival method; it nevertheless comes at a cost to the continuity of narrative voice.

The collection's success cannot be measured simply by the number of metaphors it contains. It is essential to distinguish illustrations that clarify arguments in preceding acts, those that introduce new ethical dimensions, and those that merely repeat earlier claims through fresh analogies. An inference from the movements of a newborn child to the substance of memory from a previous life, for instance, involves several unestablished intermediate steps. Its narrative effect may be astonishing, but the infant's biological behaviour does not automatically establish reincarnation. The

reference to a ritual healer's treatment of snake venom must likewise be read as a philosophical example rather than as a verified medical event.

Folk Song, Suggestion, Rasa, and Linguistic Form

The introductory song uses formulations such as "The self demands proof, yet the self itself is proof." Through their musical movement, they bring the general reader into the question. The pond, breath, and lamp become locally intelligible linguistic translations of difficult philosophical problems. This is an important achievement of creative work in Maithili. Yet the song accepts the self's self-evident status at the outset, precisely where the play announces that it will investigate the question. Thus there is a tension between the song's emotional affirmation and the debate's professed openness. Criticism must not obscure this tension under general praise of its aesthetic appeal.

The appearance of locally familiar objects—"earthen pot," "mango," "sickle," "seed," "pond," and "wave"—connects philosophical abstraction to a world of experience. Yet some metaphors within the extensive arguments carry the weight of modern educated discourse. There is, in other words, a deliberate adjustment between the purported historical period of the royal assembly and the accessibility of language to a contemporary audience. This raises a question of temporal appropriateness; because the stage-manager has already renounced the claim to verbatim historical reconstruction, linguistic modernity is not in itself a defect. It becomes one when it renders the characters' voices indistinguishable without artistic justification.

At the level of rasa, wonder and intellectual curiosity predominate. The ethical question of suffering in the fourth act creates the potential for pathos, but the play does not depict any individual life of suffering at sufficient length to realise karuṇa-rasa fully. The final silence may suggest tranquillity, but the stage-manager's open question prevents this from becoming a completed conclusion. Such restraint is praiseworthy in terms of appropriateness.

Social Voices, Assumptions about Caste, Representations of Women, and the Authority of Knowledge

In the scholarly assembly of the first part stand Udayana, Kṣaṇabhadra, the disciple, and the council. Its plurality of voices is predominantly sectarian or philosophical; voices differentiated by caste, occupation, gender, or labour rarely enter as independent speech. In the concluding collection, weavers, housewives, forest dwellers, labourers, painters, and ritual healers certainly appear, but for the most part as objects of examples intended to clarify arguments, not as autonomous speakers. The evidence of social

representation does not consist merely in the appearance of words associated with a community. The decisive question is whether that community possesses the right to experience and respond.

The example of the "weaver of Udumbaragarta" links criticism of abandoning prescribed caste duty to an accusation of religious idleness. The text thus reintroduces an archival example drawn from scholastic discourse without providing an independent account of the weaver's own social circumstances or reasons for changing his position. From the perspective of Videha's parallel history, this absence must be named. The critic must not conflate a judgement found in a classical source, its selection by the modern composition, and a social claim that the weaver's community itself has been proved culpable. The ethical risks of the example demand proper contextual analysis.

The image of the "housewife with lentils in her mouth" and the figure of a "lustful young man" make women's bodies and sexual desire into vehicles of argumentative analogy. Citing the historical existence of such material is one thing; uncritically endorsing its disparaging perspective is another. If the novel's larger intention is to make room for the voices of marginalised people, the unexamined presentation of archival examples as neutral instructional material becomes a critical challenge. The work's achievement is the gathering of numerous records; its limitation is that it does not consistently allow sufficient opposition to the power relations embedded in its sources.

A Precise Account of Evidentiary Reasoning: Proof, Conditions, and Fallacies

In Kṣaṇabhadra's proposition, "Whatever exists is momentary," existence is the reason (hetu) and momentariness the property to be established (sādhya). Without a demonstrated valid pervasion (vyāpti), the destruction of the self cannot be securely inferred. Udayana's seed analogy brings to light a possible limiting condition: the distinction between an effect's potentiality, the opportunity for its emergence, and cooperating causes. Yet even if the seed's capacity is conceded to continue, this does not by itself prove the metaphysical immutability of the self. Successful refutation of one stage of an argument and the establishment of a final positive thesis are distinct operations.

In Act II, the attempted inference from the appearance of externality in dreams to the denial of the external world in waking experience raises the problem of extending an example into a universal rule. Udayana's shared-pot example provides a practical counterposition, but one must separately ask whether shared experience necessarily requires only one particular ontology of objects. In Act III, there is a possible leap from the necessity of

self-referential language to the existence of a self-substance. How far can a specific ontological thesis be derived from the mere occurrence of a first-person expression in the utterance "I do not exist"? That remains a question for critical examination.

In Act IV, liberation is placed upon the support of a "stable self." If the opposing position defines liberation instead as the causal cessation of suffering, however, the necessity of an enduring and permanent experiencer once again requires proof. This counterposition is not being represented here as a verified original utterance from any single authoritative Buddhist text, but as a critical alternative to the claim presented in the play. The precise conclusion of this section is therefore that the text successfully animates the starting propositions, intermediate objections, concessions, and residual questions of argument; nevertheless, it would be unjustified to treat the debate's ultimate "proof" as an unassailable verdict of philosophical history.

Overall Judgement: Achievements, Weaknesses, and Questions for Further Comparison

The chief compositional achievement of Chapter –99 is the coherence of its four internal turns. The reader moves beyond the crude binary question "Does the self exist?" to the causal succession of seeds, the externality of dreams, the temporal bridge of memory, and the relationship between suffering and liberation. The limited public time of a debating hall becomes a testing ground for complex epistemological problems. Moreover, the disciple's question and Udayana's descent from his seat reveal brief psychological dimensions of the characters; because of these scenes, the play does not become a merely unreadable catalogue of doctrines.

The work has three kinds of limitation. First, the decisive teacher's long speeches are in many places answered by only brief replies from the opponent; the announcement of public equality in reasoning coexists with an actual inequality of voices. Second, philosophically disparate Buddhist positions are compressed into the fictional voice of Kṣaṇabhadra, although the composition makes this fact clear in advance. Third, after the drama concludes, the abundant collection of examples diminishes theatrical immediacy and increases the character of a scholastic source compendium. For a committed scholarly reader this expansion may be intellectually valuable; for a reader of drama it may impede the pace.

Taken together, the symbol of the conch in Chapter –100 and the witness of "I" in Chapter –99 produce a proposition worth investigating: what relationship emerges among the misidentification of an object, an individual's claim to be the witness of their own experience, and the social

recognition of a name? These two opening chapters must not be taken as sufficient grounds for deciding in advance that the ensuing novel successfully fulfils all these questions. Later sections must investigate through independent textual evidence whether Burhba, the names of the dead, networks, proof, and water burial actually transform this philosophical framework into events.

The final literary assessment is conditionally positive. “The Debate on the Establishment of the Self” is provocative, self-conscious, and rich in examples as the novel's philosophical prehistory; the succession of four acts gives imaginative movement to the question of evidence. Its decisive philosophical triumph, however, is an effect created by the drama rather than a universally accepted historical proof. The incomplete range of social voices and the unilateral authority of the collection of quotations remain genuine critical limitations. Only by holding both aspects together can the chapter be assessed impartially.

Index of Textual Evidence for Chapter −99

The following quotations are taken from direct statements in the original chapter. The printed page range 22–44 is the chapter's range as given in its contents; the exact page number of each individual sentence has not been independently established from the electronic text. The internal designations of prologue, act, epilogue, and illustration are therefore used as more reliable references.

Prologue: “What you are going to hear is not history.” — Declaration that the opposing character is fictional.

Act I: “You have shown one example. You have not shown the rule.” — The central question of pervasion.

Act II: “I accept the breaking of this pillar.” — A turning point of narrative concession.

Act III: “It is raining.” — A counterexample concerning agency and grammar.

Act III: “Master, may I ask something that troubles me?” — The disciple's independent objection.

Act IV: “Have you won for me a self worth keeping?” — The ethical question of suffering and liberation.

Epilogue: “This is not the defeat of philosophy but its work.” — A signal of the open ending.

Collection of illustrations: “The weaver of Udumbaragarta.” — A classical metaphor whose social implications must be re-examined.

Critical Section 3 | Original Chapter −98 — Who Created This World?

The exact printed page number of each individual quotation has not been verified. The chapter's printed page range is inferred from the list of chapter openings.

Chapter −98 opens with the tree's question, "Who planted me?" and the earth's reply. The setting is then identified as "Garh Narikel." The text explicitly identifies its source as "based on Udayanācārya's Nyāyakusumāñjali," and describes the audience as "schoolchildren and village spectators." Reading these two disclosures together clarifies the literary purpose: arguments concerning a creator within the Vedic–Nyāya tradition are to become theatrical dialogue within the everyday educational experience of a village. Making difficult classical thought accessible is not merely an act of summary; it is a political and pedagogical decision about the construction of a particular story. The relationship between accessibility and logical rigour, however, must itself be examined.

The second numerical indication is a mechanical marker, not a determination of the events in the original. The chapter's authentic boundaries of action must distinguish its principal dramatic scenes, the reinstatement of scenes, and the collection that follows them. To count the chorus's songs, quotations, and classical examples as equivalent to actions enacted onstage would artificially inflate event density. Establishing the textual sequence is especially difficult because two further scenes appear after what seems to have been the ending.

The table of contents gives page 45 as the beginning of Chapter −98 and page 65 as the beginning of Chapter −97. Pages 45–64 can therefore be cited as the chapter's printed range, but the electronic text does not establish an exact page within that range for every quotation. Scene numbers, speakers' names, titles of examples, and internal subdivisions offer more reliable precise locators.

From the Previous Chapter to a New Subject: From Witnessing the Self to the Maker of the World

In "The Conch and Silver," the identification of a perceived object was the focus of inquiry. In "The Debate on the Establishment of the Self," the dispute concerned the continuity of the knower who says "I." The third chapter asks whether the world's order emerged by itself or whether one must posit a maker. The sequence suggests a triad: the object of knowledge, the knowing subject, and the encompassing cause of the world. This connection arises from the questions arranged in the first three chapters; it

must not be read as a predetermined conclusion regarding the moral arguments of the whole novel.

In the opening proverb the tree asks the earth who planted it, but the earth does not provide a directly certain answer; she redirects the question towards a counterquestion. In miniature, the novel's great problem of evidence is already present: results may be perceived, causes inferred, but the complete identity of a cause is not readily established. The drama gives this uncertainty theatrical form through public humour, folk song, and the tangible presence of a potter's wheel. The silence of the opening and the assured philosophical conclusions offered later form a meaningful tension.

One ethical implication of this movement is that the narrator brings the reader before the question: "By what right do we identify the cause of the world?" Otherwise the demonstration of God might have ended as a dispute between religious doctrines. By bringing the village elder, the potter woman, a child, and Lekhani Didi into the argument as participating figures, the work stages the distribution of philosophical authority. Whether that distribution is entirely equal is a question to which the social assessment must return.

A Composition Within the Composition: The Stage-Manager, Chorus, and Time–Space

Five subsidiary settings—the public square of debate, the potter's wheel, the storehouse, the marketplace, and the house containing palm-leaf manuscripts—are constructed within a single village community. The stage-manager directly asks the spectators whether someone made the world or whether it came into being of its own accord. Through this address the audience becomes not merely an external readership but a possible judge in the staged inquiry. At one level the narrator's voice establishes the scene; at another it controls the rhythm of questions in a way that favours the philosophical case being advanced. The public character of the square, the school audience, and the village chorus combine to make the narrative present approximately one evening's public performance.

The directions stipulate "Total playing time: approximately 30 minutes" and specify minimal props—a cot, a potter's wheel, vessels, and bricks. This is an effective scenic compression of philosophical ideas. Awkward attempts at shaping clay on the wheel, arranging bricks, and the children's naming of an object are small actions, yet they alter the direction of the opponent's reasoning. The significance of an event is determined by its argumentative consequence, not by its inclusion in a numerical count.

Two temporal levels coexist. The debate in the square belongs to this evening's immediate present; the verbal thread of the elderly Kaka and the traditions of verses preserved by Lekhani Didi disclose a past extending across generations. This temporal layering is not simply an example attached to scholastic disputation: the question stretches from a contemporary child's naming of an object to the unnamed origin of the past. The authority of memory, the transmission of knowledge, and the search for the earliest source become central to this extended narrative time.

Evidence Table: Changes by Scene

Unit of the original text	Verified change on stage or in argument	Judgment of event density
Scene I: village square	The Cārvāka demands direct perception, then accepts an inference from a vessel to its unseen potter	Intellectual beginning; the evidentiary question changes
Scene II: potter woman's wheel	The relation among material, implement, and maker emerges; the Cārvāka argues that the world differs	Functional scene and objection from the opponent
Scene III: grain store	The arrangement of bricks supports an argument from organisation and maintenance; chance is offered as an alternative	Expansion of the dispute
Scene IV: village assembly	The Cārvāka acknowledges unanswered questions but does not convert; the conclusion remains open before spectators	Partial self-correction and epilogue
Post-conclusion Scene III-b	The social sign called "Tinkolī" raises the origin of communal signs	Reopening after the apparent conclusion
Post-conclusion Scene III-c	Lekhanī Dīdī's palm leaf, reliable testimony, unseen results, and the problem of the first speaker	A new dispute over verbal testimony
Collection of examples and citations	Numerous examples of dreams, production, dispositions, intended meaning, postulation, and divine speech	Predominantly scholarly compilation, not direct action

Scene One: The Opponent's Doubt and the First Inference from a Pot

Cārvāka enters in a manner associated with theatrical spectacle, but his questions are not trivial: "Who has seen this 'God'?" and "Show me a mark of his hand on even one pot!" The demand for perception and the claim of absence create the central difficulty. The Ācārya lifts a pot and asks who made it. Cārvāka readily answers that a potter woman did, although he did not himself observe her making it. This exchange is an effective theatrical device for establishing a place for inference beyond immediate observation.

Yet knowing an unseen maker from a pot and determining a single maker of the entire world are not identical evidential circumstances. The first claim rests upon extensive previous experience of what potters do; the

second raises the problem of comparable prior experience of the universe as a whole. Thus Cārvāka's initial concession applies only to the example of a manufactured object, not to the proof of God. The later scenes have Cārvāka himself articulate this difference—a positive instance of granting some intellectual independence to the opposing character.

At first the chorus repeats the doubt to generate humour. The Ācārya's composed reply and Cārvāka's conspicuously theatrical gestures distribute signs of moral superiority in advance: the patient teacher begins to seem reliable, while the loud sceptic appears unstable. The aesthetic effect is lively, but a dispassionate evaluation of the argument must attend to this emotional inequality.

Scene Two: The Potter Woman's Wheel and Knowledge Made Through Labour

The potter woman's answer in the second scene is the chapter's most substantial practical utterance. No vessel emerges without the conjunction of clay, hands, a wheel, and a form conceived in the mind. Here the maker is not merely an isolated, omnipotent will; instruments, materials, labour, and imagination also participate in production. The potter woman is not an inert example used to illustrate a doctrine. She speaks as someone who knows her own work authoritatively. Turning a rural woman's labour into a source of philosophical understanding is an important achievement of the novel.

Cārvāka's objection is precisely targeted: “The whole world is not a pot.” This marks the limits of the analogy. The Ācārya compares the ordering of stars, the movement of rivers, and the germination of rice with the shaping of a vessel. Yet the reason for considering the universe, like a dependent manufactured thing, to be a product has not been fully established. The supposed necessary connection between “it might have been otherwise” and “someone gave it shape” requires independent demonstration of its pervasion. This is a genuine intellectual difficulty in the argument, not ignorance on the part of its opposing character.

Cārvāka makes a clumsy attempt at the wheel, clay sticks to his face, and the chorus laughs. The incident evokes comic rasa and reveals a lack of practical experience in the craft; it does not establish the philosophical defeat of disbelief in God. Its effect on readers deserves critical scrutiny: the failed movement of an opponent's hands is made to stand for a failure in his reasoning. Cārvāka nevertheless repeats that acceptance of the potter of a vessel does not entail acceptance of a creator of the universe. This renewed objection partly mitigates the scene's potential one-sidedness.

Scene Three: The Storehouse Wall, Chance, and the Idea of Sustaining an Arrangement

The labour of the child Modhu as he builds a storehouse wall introduces the questions of "arrangement" and "sustaining." Bricks, suitable placement, and a wall's continued stability constitute the elements of the analogy. The Ācārya argues that intelligence must underlie both an initial conjunction and the maintenance of that conjunction. The scene does not treat organisation and construction as the same act: it draws attention to the distinct need for support after construction. This fine distinction extends the argument from one causal stage to several.

Cārvāka's reply concerning chance is more developed than his initial objection: those who see only successful results do not see the entire history of possible failures. The Ācārya honours this as a "real question." This is a central moment in the drama's ethics of dialogue. The learned advocate does not silence his opponent; instead he warns the public gathering not to become a "crowd throwing mud." At this point philosophical disputation becomes a lesson in the public conduct of reason.

At the level of scientific or philosophical testing, however, the existence of natural regularities does not lead to a universally accepted direct conclusion that intentional planning exists. Natural processes, self-organisation, cooperating causes, and selection require separate consideration. Statements such as "rain clouds do not choose for themselves" are made in a style suited to performance, but do not amount to a response to a developed alternative account of natural laws. This imbalance should not be converted into an eternal verdict either for or against theism; it is a logical limitation of the drama.

Scene Four: Restraint, the Limits of Concession, and the Open Ending

In the final assembly the Ācārya focuses the problem of chance upon the first conjunction of atoms. A decisive scenic change occurs between his statement and Cārvāka's hesitation. Cārvāka says, "I have no ready answer to this question, Ācārya. Not tonight." This demonstrates self-restraint; the text does not declare that the opponent has become a believer. From this perspective the drama's actual victory is not conversion, but the ability to acknowledge an unanswered question.

The Ācārya's injunction, "Not blind faith. Not surrender. Only an honest gaze," proposes another ethics of reasoning. Cārvāka, too, says that he will go home asking better questions; whether he will accept God or continue to doubt remains open. The final chorus returns the question of the creator to the audience. This combination of emotional closure and philosophical

indeterminacy succeeds as educational drama because it leaves intellectual independence to the reader.

But reading this openness alongside the extensive collection of proofs in the latter part reveals a tension. The drama insists that the question remain open; the subsequent compilation elaborates the case for an omniscient God. If both are treated as equally definitive pronouncements of one narrator, the drama's candid uncertainty weakens. The ending of the scenes and the philosophical compilation must therefore be distinguished as different levels of discourse.

Scene Three-B: The Naming of "Tinkoli" and the Social Construction of Verbal Meaning

A distinctive oddity is that after the community's final salutation comes "Scene Three-B." Elder Kaka announces the name "Tinkoli" for an unnamed object. The children's playful disagreement over names gradually becomes a scene establishing a social sign. The fundamental question is an old one: on what grounds does a sound come to carry a particular meaning? Kaka's "thread" becomes a metaphor for the transmission of language across generations.

Cārvāka immediately points out that the direct agency of a known elder has been witnessed here, and that this can also be read against the necessity of God. He then offers the possibilities of communal agreement and slow change. This counterargument is among the chapter's strongest moments of plurality. The claim that a first individual must always have tied the first knot of a linguistic sign may be weaker than an account in which traditions develop gradually. The scene does not establish the universal pervasion that words cannot exist without one original bestower of names.

Elder Kaka acknowledges the limits of his knowledge and passes the question to the Ācārya. This matters to the drama's construction of authority: the elder is a witness to tradition, not a final, omniscient speaker. The naming scene may be connected with the later novel's problems of names, testimonies, and records. Yet without testing whether these questions actually recur in subsequent passages, such a connection cannot be declared an established intertextual relationship.

Scene Three-C: Lekhani Didi, Verbal Testimony, and the Palm Leaf

In "Scene Three-C," Lekhani Didi tends the palm-leaf manuscript, and the reliability of truthful utterance becomes the focal problem. Cārvāka asks on what grounds claims concerning unseen consequences and a world after death should be accepted. Lekhani Didi first offers the example of a mother's warning about fire: a child trusts a reliable person without personally having undergone a burn. This ordinary experience makes clear

two conditions for assessing authoritative testimony: the speaker must know the subject, and must lack a reason to deceive.

The illustration is powerful because it arises from familiar experience, but its limitation is equally evident. A mother may have directly witnessed that fire burns; the illustration does not automatically establish that direct knowledge of unseen karmic consequences, a posthumous world, or an omniscient creator is necessarily possible. The utterance of a trustworthy person, the continuity of tradition, and the proof of a superhuman omniscient first speaker require three separate demonstrations. Lekhani Didi herself rightly says that antiquity is not a sufficient reason for knowledge; this principle must also be applied consistently to her account of Vedic authority.

Her social presence has particular importance. The potter woman shapes material objects with her hands; Lekhani Didi preserves the tradition of writing. The two women embody, respectively, material production and textual preservation as forms of knowledge. This is no mere ornament: it redistributes the foundational labour of knowing within the village. Yet Lekhani Didi defers the final answer about the authorship of scripture to the Ācārya, limiting her own assertion with "I merely copy the pages." A woman is thus present as a source of knowledge, while the institution of final doctrinal judgement remains with the male teacher: an internal asymmetry in the composition.

Scenes Inserted after the Ending: A Genuine Structural Incongruity

The four scenes are followed in the text by the stage-manager's epilogue, the chorus's concluding couplet, and the collective salutation of all the characters. The text then supplies "Scene Three-B" and "Scene Three-C," before announcing once again that "The play is over." This sequence cannot be dismissed as a mere mistake in scene numbering. The reader first understands the story to have closed, and only afterwards do scenes assigned earlier numbers restart it. The rhythm of the narrative and the development of its educational purpose are consequently disrupted.

The two interpolated scenes are not inappropriate in content. Reasoning from a made object at the potter's wheel, from arrangement and support at the storehouse, from linguistic signs in the marketplace, and from trusted utterance in Lekhani Didi's scene forms a coherent sequence of proofs. Placing the marketplace and palm-leaf episodes before the final village assembly would make the progression of narrative causality clearer: from manufacturing to maintenance, from language to trust, and from trust to the final doubt. In the present arrangement the premature ending interrupts that progression.

This observation is not an instruction to reconstruct the original work; it is an account of the effect of the form in which the text stands. A critic should not count the supplementary scenes as newly independent chapters of the novel. They are more accurately described as dramatically discontinuous units within Chapter –98. Clarifying their position in a subsequent edition would be a genuine opportunity for literary refinement.

The Criterion of Navya-Nyāya: Effect, Arrangement, Words, and Trust

The play presents simplified versions of four arguments: inference of a maker from a produced effect (kāryāt); inference of organising intelligence from suitable conjunction or sustaining arrangement (āyojanāt/dhṛtyādeḥ); inference of an original maker of linguistic signs from the determinacy of word-meaning relations (padāt); and inference of an omniscient first speaker from trusted utterance (pratyayataḥ). These classical terms are explicitly linked to the scenes in the original text. It cannot, however, be claimed without collating editions that the entire verbal order and interpretation of the original Sanskrit Nyāyakusumāñjali have been reproduced unchanged in this adaptation.

If being an effect is taken as the reason (hetu) and the world as the subject (pakṣa), the question arises how the world's status as an effect has itself been established, and whether all its components are effects of the same kind. A limiting condition might be that manufactured, directly observable human objects acquire a desired form through specific instruments and trained skill; extending the same evidence to the whole world requires testing other possible causes. This is not a verbatim judgement about Udayana's own philosophical procedure, but a Navya-Nyāya-oriented examination of the inferences made by characters in the novel.

Three further distinctions require attention: the apparent order of an "arrangement" does not itself establish the necessity of intended planning; a community's use of signs does not itself establish the necessity of one original giver of signs; and trustworthy testimony does not itself establish the necessity of an omniscient first speaker. In each case the pervasion between reason and conclusion must be distinguished from the reasoning offered. If the opposing party presents natural regularity, communal linguistic development, and limited human teachers as alternatives, they cannot be called mere ignorance. An achievement of the play is that Cārvāka progressively names just these alternatives; its limitation is that none receives sufficiently extended examination.

The Examples from *Nyāyakusumāñjali*: From Dramatic Events to a Scholastic Anthology

After the announcement that the play has ended, a section titled "Nyāyakusumāñjali: Stories, Examples, and Quotations" appears. The stage-manager again tells stories to his disciple and the people of the village. The mode of action changes at this point: explanatory compilation takes precedence over dialogic philosophical dispute. The smell of musk, an unborn child, drowning in a pond in a dream, a hungry person's dreamed sweets, the sign of a puppet, the first scorpion, fire, birds, a magician, a parrot, an official, and a house on the banks of the Ganges are all scholastic illustrations placed within the fictional world. It would be a methodological error to treat each as an actual narrated event.

Drowning in a pond during a dream and the hungry dreamer's sweets offer different means of testing the validity of cognition. Fear or satisfaction in a dream may fail a test after waking. These instances open a question about the relationship between successful practical activity and validity. They make a coherent intellectual bridge to the object-illusion of Chapter –100 and the dream-world debate of Chapter –99, but provide no grounds for inventing an actual character who drowned as an event in the novel.

The familiar example, "Fat Devadatta does not eat during the day," the indication of a place by reference to the bank of the Ganges, and the reversed intentions of a lover and traveller raise distinct questions of language and sentence meaning. Discussion of object-based evidence gradually expands to intention, secondary signification, and postulation (arthāpatti). The collection can thus be useful to a reader: the village play is followed by an archive of philosophical semantics. But its considerable size does not fit the announced thirty-minute performance for children. The independent rhythm of the play ends, and a compilation-centred course of study begins.

History, Caste, Women, and Environmental Representation

The potter woman's wheel, rice, river, seasons, and grain storehouse turn the rural environment into a source of philosophical reasoning. Clay is not merely an inert object of worship or metaphor: to acquire a useful shape it requires heat, labour, imagination, and social demand. At the same time, assertions that the river will not take a "wrong turn" and that seasons everywhere follow a uniform order present natural complexity as excessively well regulated. From the perspective of environmental narratology, comparisons with local uncertainty about water, flood, erosion, and change in the subsequent novel are necessary. Here, merely asserting a necessary order does not justify accepting nature as governed by an invariably fixed design.

The collection contains traditional conceptions about the origins of an early scorpion, plants, and human communities. The claim that scorpions arise from rotting dung is not an established conclusion of modern biology. It should therefore be identified as a historical example within a scholastic tradition of reasoning, not a scientific fact. Likewise, accounts of the successive "decline" of social customs and of the origins of the earliest caste distinctions are morally charged evaluations in historical sources. They cannot be adopted as neutral assertions without examination of social history.

Videha's parallel-history method would ask for how long the drama permits independent voices to the professional knowledge of the potter woman and the ideas of Lekhani Didi, keeper of the palm leaves. Village children participate in naming, but the final authoritative pronouncement still falls to an older male teacher. Merely mentioning caste-marked occupations—potter, mason, writer, teacher—is insufficient. More significant is their legitimate right to speak and the objections born of their experience. This chapter's introduction of the philosophy of labour is noteworthy, but its distribution of philosophical decision-making remains systematically unequal.

Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti, and the Responsive Reader

The questioning rhythm of the folk song—the tree asks and the earth smiles—makes a difficult question concerning the origin of the world accessible to the responsive reader's imagination. Seeking its roots, the tree arrives at its own roots: this oblique expression (vakrokti) turns causal investigation towards self-recognition. It is a memorable image for children. The song's capacity to awaken an attraction to reasoning is an aesthetic achievement, but its utterances are not logically proved conclusions. Suggestion (dhvani) creates several possible meanings; it does not replace the pervasion required by inference.

Cārvāka's face being marked with clay at the potter's wheel provides a direct occasion for humour. Yet the beauty of the debate becomes more complex when he clearly says, "Thinking is not the same as losing." This balances the comic superiority granted to the other characters. Responsive appreciation and critical reading must proceed together: a reader can admire the Ācārya's patience while scrutinising the still-valid force of his opponent's arguments.

The final couplet's injunction, "Ask, think," prevents the audience from becoming merely devotional. Measured by artistic appropriateness (aucitya), the drama's original epilogue is therefore coherent. The incongruity lies at the level of structure: insertion of the intermediate scenes afterwards and the very long scholastic collection suspend the earlier

effect of children's theatre. Philosophical experience organised through rasa and extended philosophical instruction are both important, but do not possess the same narrative pace. Giving that difference a clear editorial form could strengthen their combined effect.

Overall Assessment of Chapter −98 and the Question for the Next Section

The achievement of Chapter −98 is not that it establishes the creator's existence through an incontrovertible historical or logical demonstration. Rather, it brings Udayanācārya's demanding arguments onto the rural stage of Garh Narikel, where labour, language, inherited memory, and the preservation of texts become instruments of thought. Cārvāka never relinquishes his right to question. The didactic play is thereby partly saved from the danger of becoming a single-track declaration of religious doctrine.

Three principal limits remain clear. First, the philosophical leap from a handmade pot to authorship of the entire universe is not fully supported by evidence; possible natural or communal alternatives supplied by the opponent receive little development. Second, the placement of intermediate scenes after the stage epilogue is a structural flaw. Third, the collection of classical examples does not maintain a consistently adequate critical distance from unverified historical or scientific claims and signs of social hierarchy. These conclusions rest on alternatives, sequences, and quotations actually found in the original chapter; they are not verdicts imposed in advance upon the whole work.

The first three chapters now form a confluence of questions: the object directly perceived can be misidentified; the character of the testimony of "I" remains contested; and the cause of the visible world is not simply present before us. Chapter −97, "The Chintāmaṇi Jewel," may bring into more direct relation a Navya-Nyāya treatise, the value of knowledge, and the social conditions of storytelling, but that relation can become an evaluative conclusion only after examining its actual text. The present critical result is conditionally positive: the public vernacular adaptation of Nyāya has literary value, while its evidentiary discipline and the ordering of the work require rigorous editorial examination.

Chapter −98: Register of Evidence Verified Against the Original Text

This index was checked against particular scenes and source sections of Chapter −98 in the original combined novel. Its contents give pages 45–64 as the chapter range; no independent verification has yet established the exact printed page location of each sentence.

Opening saying: “The tree asked, ‘Who planted me?’” — The metaphorical question of cause and effect.

Scene One, Cārvāka: “Who has seen this ‘God’?” — Demand for perception and the claim of absence.

Scene Two, Cārvāka: “The whole world is not a pot.” — Limits of an analogy.

Scene Three, Ācārya: “That, too, is a real question.” — Recognition of the opposing position.

Scene Four, Cārvāka: “I have no ready answer to this question.” — Partial indeterminacy.

Scene Four, Ācārya: “Not blind faith. Not surrender. Only an honest gaze.” — The ethics of narrative inquiry.

Scene Three-B, Cārvāka: “Thinking is not the same as losing.” — Dialogic plurality.

Scene Three-C, Lekhani Didi: “An inference, however old it may be and however many times it is repeated, remains an inference.” — The limits of evidence.

Post-dramatic source section: “The episode of drowning in a pond in a dream.” — An illustration of epistemic validity, not an immediate event of the novel.

Post-dramatic source section: “The house on the bank of the Ganges” and “the example of fat Devadatta.” — Linguistic intention and postulation.

Critical Section 4 | Original Chapter −97 — The Chintāmaṇi Jewel

The precise printed page number of each individual quotation remains unverified. Acts, characters, and titles within the collection are used as evidentiary locators.

An independent count of the relevant part of the original combined Word text yielded 5,307 Unicode character groups within the boundaries of the principal chapter; a difference of two units may arise from different handling of punctuation and joined forms. This small discrepancy does not change the subject of the criticism, but it would be misleading to call both counts a single definitive number of "words." In the contents the chapter begins on page 65, while the following Chapter −96 begins on page 88; pages 65–87 are therefore the appropriate range for the chapter, not precise page citations for individual quotations.

The source material comprises a prologue, four acts, an epilogue, an explanatory note, and then a collection of illustrations and quotations entitled "Tattvacintāmaṇi." The principal characters are Gaṅgeśa, the Buddhist, the Mīmāṃsaka, the disciple, and the stage-manager. The explanatory comment explicitly identifies the Buddhist, Mīmāṃsaka, and disciple as composite representative characters, not biographical portraits of named historical persons. This precludes treating the play as a transcript of a historically attested debate conducted by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. It is a creative reconstruction in modern Maithili, and its historical and literary values must be examined by different standards.

To conduct that inquiry, the progression from proposition through objection and revision to remaining question has been extracted for each act. A paragraph indicating action is not equivalent to a count of events: a long discussion may change only the intellectual state of the dispute, while a very small stage action—placing a conch on the table or smoke rising from a lamp—may transform the whole argumentative situation. Without this distinction, a reliable evaluation of the chapter's narrative density is impossible.

The Philosophical Sequence at the Beginning of the Trilogy: From Illusion to a Method of Testing

Chapter −100, "The Conch and Silver," raised the problem of mistaken identification and the reliability of perception. Chapter −99, "The Debate on the Establishment of the Self," questioned the continuity of the knower. Chapter −98, "Who Created This World?", presented dramatic dispute over the inference of a creator. In Chapter −97 these questions

return, but the subject has now become the very method of dispute: before a claim is accepted, can its definition withstand an opponent's attack? The order reveals a critical ascent—from object, through knower and cause, to the public examination of the definition of proof.

The first saying of this section connects mental steadiness with the value of a jewel. By saying, "If the mind is steady, even a clod is a diamond," the composition moves attention from the rarity of an external gem to the discipline of understanding. In the play, Gaṅgeśa recognises the weakness of his own first statement and reconstructs it instead of defending it. Thus the jewel becomes not a final truth already possessed, but a metaphor for intellectual caution acquired through repeated testing. Nevertheless, the successful poetic image and the formal validity of a specific argument are not the same thing. A poetic conclusion cannot replace a logical demonstration.

One formal feature distinguishes this chapter from the preceding village performance: the setting changes to a debating hall in Mithila. Folk society does not disappear entirely: the stage-manager, disciple, mason, pot, and appeals to village listeners remain. But control over the discourse becomes concentrated within specialist debate. This alteration raises the question of how the popular accessibility of philosophy and the difficult specialisation of Navya-Nyāya can coexist in one narrative. The chapter offers a powerful dramatic indication of an answer, though not a complete one.

Prologue: The Mason's Mortar and the Weight of Knowledge

Two lamps are onstage, one burning and the other unlit; an earthen pot stands to the side. With these few objects, the opening constructs images of observation, absence, and agency. The stage-manager draws a parallel between testing a mason's mortar and making a logician's conclusion capable of bearing pressure. Weak mortar makes a sound wall impossible; an imprecise reason cannot bear the weight of a doctrine. The scenic material is therefore not decoration, but a tangible discipline for concepts.

In the opening announcement, the stage-manager presents the Buddhist logician's acute scepticism as an opposition to be faced, without simply declaring him wicked or ignorant. The precision of the opponent's attack becomes a condition of the protagonist's intellectual standing. Gaṅgeśa may even reject his own initial definition. This declared principle repeatedly generates plot throughout the play. The point is that the real event of the dispute lies first in the alteration of a logical position, not merely in the replacement of one sentence with another.

The folk song's image, "To one who is steady within, even clay appears a jewel," turns in a slightly different direction from the main method of the

prose: it associates true knowledge with steadiness of mind, whereas the play emphasises external objections and evidence. An attentive reader may find these meanings complementary, but mental composure must not be treated as sufficient proof of factual truth. The suggestion of the proverb and the propositions of the Nyāya method speak in different registers within this internal tension.

Act I: The Causality of the Invocation and the Question of Conditions

Immediately after offering a religious salutation, Gaṅgeśa asks whether an auspicious invocation (maṅgalācaraṇa) actually produces an effect. The Buddhist responds with the example of Udayana's Kiraṇāvalī, completed without an explicit invocation. If every successful undertaking required such an invocation, the counterexample would challenge the rule. The opponent is not introduced merely to perform an ornamental denial: he creates an actual obstruction to the universal scope of the opening assertion. Gaṅgeśa acknowledges the initial difficulty and rewrites his explanation of causality.

In Gaṅgeśa's revised reply, the invocation is not the direct producer of the work, but a remover of possible obstacles. If no obstacle exists in the first place, the absence of a need to remove one does not falsify a conditional rule. An example such as "There is no need for someone to remove a lock from an already open door" makes this intelligible. This offers an approach to the Navya-Nyāya examination of limiting conditions (upādhi), although no claim is made here that every term corresponds exactly to a Sanskrit definition in the source treatise. Restricting the claim's domain is the play's first intellectual turn.

The Buddhist promptly raises another objection: if the presence or absence of an obstacle cannot be observed independently, successes and failures can both be explained by invoking the same invisible condition. This reaches the heart of epistemology. The existence of a causal condition and its testability are two different criteria. Gaṅgeśa's answer adds everyday examples of conditional causation and the support of scripture and established conduct, but does not adequately specify a method for independently testing the invisible impediment. The act therefore ends not in complete proof, but in an exercise in keeping a rule open to questioning.

The Mīmāṃsaka's Voice: Verbal Testimony and the Unequal Public Distribution of Evidence

In the first act, the Mīmāṃsaka enters to raise the issue of the authority of Vedic injunctions. He does not generally agree with the Buddhist, but he also presses Gaṅgeśa to provide evidence for the causality of an auspicious

invocation. This triangular dialogue prevents the debating hall from becoming a simple contest with only a victor and a vanquished opponent. The Buddhist's emphasis on perception and inference, the Mīmāṃsaka's scriptural authority, and Gaṅgeśa's progressively evidence-based defence arise from different grounds. This difference is the genuine beginning of plurality of voices.

Gaṅgeśa argues that agreement between scriptural statements and inherited social practice strengthens the reliability of a causal claim. But social practice is itself influenced by social relations, caste privileges, and access to writing. The continuous repetition of the utterances of those historically allowed to speak or cite scripture does not automatically constitute inclusive evidence. At this point Videha's parallel-history criterion would require inquiry not merely into the authority of accepting a Vedic injunction but into its social implementation, the obligation to obey it, and the penalties for disagreement. The chapter opens this question but does not stage its social consequences at length.

Act II: Mixed Cognition of Conch and Silver and the Separation of Grounds

Before the disciple, Gaṅgeśa tests the initial limits of valid cognition by examining the illusion of seeing silver where there is a conch. A demonstrative "here" may be correct while the property "silver" is erroneous. This provides an explicit intertextual bridge to the first chapter, "The Conch and Silver." Here the author relocates an established symbol in a fresh dramatic situation: earlier it was the subject of a story about illusion; now it exposes a defect in the definition of knowledge. The recurrence is more than the return of the same word: the function of the question has changed.

Gaṅgeśa attempts to make cognition intelligible through close examination of relations rather than treating it as one indivisible statement. The disciple immediately asks whether a judgement that is half correct and half incorrect is not a contradiction. The reply distinguishes truth values attributable to different specified aspects of a complex cognition. One might compare this with the decomposition of a statement into components in modern analytic reasoning, but equating Navya-Nyāya's relational grammar of avacchedaka with simple modern propositional decomposition would be incautious. The play's scenic simplification is at once a pedagogical advantage and a formal limitation.

The Buddhist gives the example of a bird present in the crown of a tree but absent from its roots. Presence and absence of a property in different parts of one thing are not contradictory if the relevant location is specified. Gaṅgeśa insists upon designating the "part" and the "time." Conceptually,

this provides an entrance to the idea of a delimiter (avacchedaka). The narrative beauty here lies not in presenting a long list of formidable technical expressions, but in clarifying meaning through a concrete image of a tree.

The Firing Pot and the Specification of Time: Philosophy's Entry into Temporality

The closing objection of the second act concerns a pot that is black before firing and reddish afterwards. The truth of the utterance "This very pot is black" changes when its temporal reference changes. Gaṅgeśa replies that the original cognition was already time-bound: "black before firing" and "black now" are different temporally delimited assertions. Time thus ceases to be only the background to narrative events and becomes a decisive constituent of the validity of a statement.

Narratology must distinguish story time and discourse time in this scene. The pot is present onstage during the current evening, but its history of manufacture, its earlier blackness, and its firing are reconstructed through dialogue. A long span of existence is compressed into the descriptive scene. For this reason the number of words devoted to an action does not measure its actual event density. A summary of prior events changes the reasoning of the present conversation: the reader is compelled to connect the temporal circumstances of an object's history with the validity of cognition.

At an ethical level, this subtle condition of time may later offer a means of examining changing states of testimony, documents, and memory in the novel, but no particular later event should be imposed here before examining the following chapters. The current scene is sufficiently strong in itself: once the temporal reference of a verified assertion is removed, the assertion's meaning changes. This is also a useful general methodological warning about the authority of modern archives.

Act III: The First Definition of Pervasion and the Opponent's Challenge

A light wisp of smoke rising from a lamp wick is the concrete entrance sign for the third act. Gaṅgeśa initially tries to define vyāpti, or pervasion, by saying that the reason does not occur where the probandum is absent. The Buddhist invokes a wholly affirmative case and asks how one can test a locus of the "absence of the probandum" if there is no suitable negative domain. The play allows the opponent's criticism to prevail: Gaṅgeśa explicitly says that he abandons the first attempt. This act of self-correction is a principal event, not an ornamental moment of dialogue.

Thereafter several formulations concerning co-presence and relations among loci of absence are presented. Gaṅgeśa mentions a third and fourth attempt, but condenses dense Navya-Nyāya distinctions into very brief utterances. The reader receives a narrative of method—an opponent identifies a problem involving a condition or absence, and the definition is narrowed—but does not see a separate formal demonstration of the validity of each definition. This literary condensation increases the pace while making rigorous specialist verification harder.

Gaṅgeśa's appeal to "be impressed not by the counting but by the method" is a narrative achievement. The prestige of reasoning is shown not through an immovable conclusion, but through a definition improved after surviving failure. The opposite danger is that repeated refinement may be treated as proof of ultimate success in itself. The Buddhist's insistence remains valuable: does the new definition withstand every relevant countercase, or only those made available onstage? Exposing that difference is central to the criticism.

Smoke and Fire: Observation, Limiting Conditions, and Unlimited Experience

The disciple asks: smoke and fire have been seen together in a kitchen, but who has seen every fire in the world? This expresses the experiential limits of a general rule. Gaṅgeśa suggests that repeated observation and the search for opposing examples can increase confidence in pervasion. The play does not deny the inferential leap between a limited sample of observations and a universal conclusion: it seeks suitable grounds for the leap. The disciple's ordinary question is consequently intellectually acute.

Yet saying "a conjunction that has never failed is a rule" does not settle the difficulty. How many observations were made, in what circumstances, and how can the absence of a possible limiting condition be assured? The possibility of smoke without the apparent flame, or different relations involving fire without visible smoke, requires care in Nyāya examples. It would be inappropriate to insert the compulsory methods of a modern scientific laboratory into this account of the original; the reader may nevertheless ask whether agreement in presence (anvaya), agreement in absence (vyatireka), regular conjunction, and the limits of inferential pervasion have been sufficiently distinguished in the story.

The rising smoke is a very small outward event onstage, yet within it unfolds an intense debate about causality, the universality of knowledge, and the limits of observation. Its eventfulness should not be measured by the number of bodily movements, but by changes of intellectual position, responses from opponents, and the successive forms of a definition.

Act IV: Earth, the Pot, and the Delimitation of the Subject of the Inference of God

Gaṅgeśa lifts a pot from the table and infers a maker of earth and the other elements. This time, before asking who produces the world, the Buddhist demands precision concerning what exactly constitutes the "subject" (pakṣa) of the question. If "earth and the remaining elements" remain vague, do they constitute one uniform disputed subject? This is not verbal play. If the subject itself keeps changing, the eventual conclusion of the inference may differ from the claim originally advanced. The Buddhist's role as an opponent is most active in this act.

The example of a sprout exposes a difficulty for the main inference: when being produced is taken as the ground for a maker, the supposed general class also contains natural things whose causal processes differ from the manufacture of a pot. Gaṅgeśa responds by restricting the subject to the disputed elements—earth, water, fire, and air. Although this caution is ethically admirable, since it attempts to avoid changing the question midway through a dispute and declaring victory, it is not an independent proof. The grounds for treating the material elements as "effects," the nature of their production, and the inferred kind of maker still demand separate tests.

In Navya-Nyāya terminology, delimiting the subject, proving the presence of the reason, and excluding limiting conditions from the pervasion are distinct questions. The dialogue joins them along a single narrative thread, but philosophical criticism must separate them again. Intertextually, the potter's wheel and pot of Chapter –98 return; now there is less of a concrete scene of labour and more of a specification of the subject of evidence. The recurring symbol performs a new function and is therefore not simply unnecessary repetition.

Defining Agency: Coincidence in Time and Effective Causation

The Buddhist asks for a definition of agency in terms of the presence of knowledge, desire, and effort. Gaṅgeśa himself refutes so weak a definition: we know of, desire, and attempt to act in relation to many things without thereby becoming the producers of all those things. This distinguishes mere co-presence of the qualities associated with a maker from actual effective causation. At this moment the novel turns epistemological caution into a memorable event of dialogue—the protagonist sacrifices a weak version of his own proposed position.

The subsequent refinement requires the maker's knowledge, desire, and effort to stand in a genuine causal relation to the production of the object, rather than merely accompanying the object. But questions still remain:

how is effective causation itself identified? Must the production of primary inanimate elements necessarily involve the same causal form as a familiar craft? Unless these matters are examined, the conclusion "God" may remain an interpretation of the proposed predicate rather than an inevitable result of established inference.

The embodied maker depends upon the causes of the maker's body, and the fear of infinite regress introduces the idea of a disembodied maker. This argument gives the last act additional narrative force. Nevertheless, rejecting infinite regress and proving the existence of one particular independent conscious creator are different propositions. Gaṅgeśa narrows his conclusion by declaring that this maker is "not a bigger human being," while the Buddhist does not announce total conversion. Both the chapter's intellectual honesty and its limits reside in the residue of that disagreement.

The Nature of the Outcome: Not Conversion, but Partial Acceptance of a Method of Reasoning

At the end of the fourth act, after a long silence, the Buddhist explicitly says that he is not wholly convinced, but no longer believes that the steps of the argument could have been dismissed lightly. The dramatic precision of this utterance matters. Gaṅgeśa's victory does not result in religious agreement; rather, the opponent's estimation of the seriousness of the method has risen. The plot's final alteration is in one person's level of acceptance, not in the final resolution of a universal philosophical dispute.

Gaṅgeśa himself restricts his definition of victory: not a raised voice, but an examined statement capable of withstanding the blows of evidence. The stage-manager leaves judgement to the reader or listener in the epilogue. By preserving this limit the drama activates the responsive reader: those in the assembly are not merely an audience that applauds, but become answerable to the final question. Yet to open a question and genuinely offer readers alternatives requires critical attention both to the linguistic respect accorded to opponents and to the substantive equality of their opportunities to reason.

The events within the debating hall are framed by the stage-manager speaking from outside the action. Within that theatrical layer the characters speak, while the stage-manager addresses the audience with a declared purpose. Expository paragraphs then list representative subjects drawn from an actual Sanskrit treatise. Treating these three levels as one completely omniscient narrator would be a mistake. Narrative reliability requires a different measure at each level.

Order of Narration, Duration, Focalisation, and Stage Composition

The four acts suggest a sequence within a single evening, but past examples involving Udayana, earlier encounters with smoke and fire, the history of a pot's firing, and the extended period during which books are composed are compressed into the dramatic present. Numerous examples from story time are accommodated within the confined span of stage time. Rather than full analeptic scenes, argumentative recollections predominate: temporal episodes become grounds for reasoning from scene to scene, not chapters in a character's biography.

Focalisation does not remain fixed in any one character's inner consciousness. Gaṅgeśa's arguments receive extended development, the Buddhist's objections are acute, the disciple's questions arise from ordinary curiosity, and the Mīmāṃsaka's voice raises the claims of classical authority. The stage-manager allocates the occasions for their speech and directs the spectator's interpretation. The drama depends comparatively heavily on external communication; the characters' inner lives, personal losses, and relational dilemmas receive little space. Hence intellectual polyphony is significant, but psychological characterisation is restricted.

The burning lamp, rising smoke, placed conch, and lifted pot—four physical signs—give the acts a material ground. They are not a mechanical checklist of symbols, but a way to make the question of evidence visible: what appears before the eyes raises questions about the inference of unseen relations. By contrast, no independently testable stage scene directly demonstrates the removal of obstacles by an auspicious invocation or the agency of God. The actors advance from visible physical signs to invisible claims. The effectiveness and internal tension of the drama both depend on this inequality.

Evidence Table: Events and Transformations by Act

Section of original text	Narratively attested transformation	Limit of examination
Prologue	The stage-manager links a mason's mortar to the endurance of evidence	Declaration of method, not an event count
Act I: invocation	Udayana offers a counterexample; Gaṅgeśa stipulates conditions for removing obstacles	Unseen impediments require independent testing
Act II: conch and silver	Mixed cognition; spatial conditions concerning a tree part and temporal conditions concerning a fired pot	Space and time are specified; verification against variants remains
Act III: smoke and fire	An initial account of invariable concomitance is rejected and refined	All-positive reasons, limiting conditions, universality
Act IV: agency	Delimiting the subject, the objection from sprouts, defining an effective cause	A conclusion about a maker of the world remains conditional

Section of original text	Narratively attested transformation	Limit of examination
Epilogue	The Buddhist does not fully convert but accepts a stricter method	The reader's judgment remains open
Collection of examples and citations	Assemblage of oral reports, analogy, postulation, and philosophical sayings	Neither stage events nor historically verified conversations

The Illustrative Collection after the Principal Drama: Boundaries and Categories of Knowledge

After the chapter's epilogue and the departure of its characters comes "Tattvacintāmaṇi: Stories, Examples, and a Collection of Quotations." It contains folklore concerning Gaṅgeśa's childhood; the Prābhākara interpretation of shell and silver; the postulation that Devadatta is outside the house; the counteracting action of a gem or mantra upon fire; "Oṃ" and "Atha"; analogies involving the gavaya, a donkey, broccoli, a zebra, a wooden doll, and a boy reporting news, among other instances. These are not independent dramatic scenes enacted in the four acts. They should be distinguished as appendix-like instructional material even though they physically form part of the same chapter.

Particular care is needed to differentiate types of knowledge in this section. The original itself identifies the story of Gaṅgeśa's childhood practice in a cremation ground and sudden attainment of knowledge as "folklore"; it cannot be historically verified without independent sources. Statements about a mantra or gem preventing fire from burning may belong to traditional philosophical illustrations of causal conditions; they are not experimental facts established by physical science. Broccoli and zebras provide intelligible contemporary analogies and should not be presented as directly enacted scenes from Gaṅgeśa's historical Sanskrit debates. This classification protects the pedagogical achievement without falsifying history.

The collection brings together several distinct approaches to knowledge—inference, analogy, testimony, postulation, and memory. The main play itself acknowledges that it does not present the complete technical detail of the analogy and testimony divisions of Gaṅgeśa's treatise. This admission marks the limits of the prose narrative candidly. Nevertheless, the considerable expansion after the dramatic conclusion loosens the concentration previously achieved. Presenting the collection as a "study companion" or "embedded appendix" could increase editorial clarity.

Status of Source Utterances: Quotation, Instruction, and Historical Claim

The "quotations" section offers brief prose statements concerning auspicious invocations, praise of Vināyaka, good conduct, knowledge of

self, action, the Bhagavad Gītā, Purāṇas, smṛti, Brahman, and the agency of God. It would be inappropriate to assign all the same evidential status. Some are clearly identified references to classical texts; others are general philosophical paraphrases; still others resemble quotations without providing source particulars. They cannot be treated as verbatim traditional quotations before the edition, original language, verbal sequence, and contextual location have been checked. The critical source register leaves this limitation explicit.

A statement such as "the twice-born who remembers a previous birth" places social classification in relation to the authority to know. Under Videha's parallel-history test, this is not only a spiritual proposition but also a question about who is deemed eligible for knowledge. Meanwhile, the child observing a wooden doll and the learner in a vegetable market suggest experience open to everyone. Restricted classical eligibility and freely accessible sensory and social learning are present within the same collection. That contradiction calls for investigation, not automatic reconciliation.

The language of the quotations is often instructive and categorical, unlike the reciprocal questioning that sustained the main drama. The change of mode increases narrative distance: the listener may become a recipient of regulations rather than someone deciding for themselves. Consequently, a difference appears between the Navya-Nyāya ideal of corrigible statements and the assured tone of the gathered teachings. This is a fundamental testing point for the ethics of evidence across the complete work.

Rasa, Dhvani, Aucitya, and a Critique of Language and Style

The opening proverb's reversal of "clod" and "diamond" is an appealing instance of oblique expression (vakrokti). Clay, pot, mason's mortar, conch, tree, smoke, and lamp give philosophical experience forms that are intelligible in everyday life. The sense of wonder here arises not from occult marvels but from curiosity about the conditions of truth in ordinary objects. The disciple's short question does not produce a culmination of pathos or heroism; it creates a cautious mood of inquiry. This particular emotional arrangement is better described without mechanically imposing the categories of classical rasa theory.

The teacher's humility is repeatedly praised, and the opposing Buddhist gradually receives respect. The language returns to expressions of the kind "test first," "make it more precise," and "I shall not defend my first answer." This repetition creates a rhythm of method, although at times several forms of the same maxim diminish the concentration of its effect. At the end of a long drama the stage-manager's renewed summary of the

entire procedure increases clarity while risking excessive direction of the reader's independent creation of meaning.

On the criterion of appropriateness, the simple stage objects, four-act sequence, and continuing participation of the opponent are coherent. The principal tension lies in the abrupt shift from the play to the collection of quotations. If the author's purpose is to bring folk theatre, instruction in Navya-Nyāya, and textual compilation into the same chapter, that intention needs to be signalled to the reader in advance. Otherwise encyclopaedic expansion after dramatic closure can overwhelm the plot's last resonance. The objection is not to length in itself, but to the need for clarity concerning the boundaries of genres.

Event Density, Social Context, and Overall Judgement

As regards events, physical action is restricted: a scholar's seat, the lamp wick, a conch on the table, a pot in the hand, and departure from the assembly. Epistemic events, however, are clear. Unqualified claims about the causality of auspicious invocations become conditional; a crude definition of correct knowledge comes to require spatial and temporal precision; the first definition of pervasion is revised after the Buddhist's objection; the subject of the inference of God and the relation of agency are narrowed; and finally the opponent, without complete agreement, acknowledges methodological integrity. These stages form a coherent causal narrative of thought, and it would be unfair to dismiss them as "mere lectures."

Social representation centres mainly on classical scholars, the student, and the stage-manager. The potter woman's independent voice of labour in Chapter –98 has here become the symbolic pot; the actual potter woman does not speak onstage. The use of her manufactured object is therefore not proof of full participation by working people. Likewise, there is little representation of the human lives of those involved in rigorous intellectual testing—their families, the personal price of failure, or the consequences for their communities. Respect for a disputant within the hall is significant, but its direct narrative connection with the broader contradictions of the social world remains slight.

The section's principal achievement is its capacity for self-refuting inquiry and its respectful inclusion of the opponent. Its main limitation is that difficult Navya-Nyāya techniques are frequently condensed so strongly that they seem to have been decisively established, even where the exclusion of limiting conditions and the formal requirements of pervasion have not been elaborated sufficiently. The difference between a narrative reconstruction of a historical scholastic work and an authenticated primary text is indicated, but the source status of the illustrative and

quotation collection could have been more clearly specified. The judgement is conditionally favourable: the chapter narrates the process of thinking, not merely thought's final results.

As the discussion proceeds towards Chapter –96, "The Preservation of Memory," one question remains for investigation: how can a form of knowledge able to correct its own definitions become a social institution capable of correcting errors in memory, names, and archives? The answer can be given only after examining the actual text of the next chapter. At this point only the cumulative relationship among four chapters is established: illusion in perception, dispute about the knower, inference of a creator, and the self-examination of evidence form four distinct and successive dramatic experiences.

Chapter –97: Index of Evidence Verified from the Original Text

The brief extracts below were checked against Chapter –97 of the original combined Word text. The reader can confirm pages 65–87 as the chapter range from the contents; the exact printed page number of each quotation has not been independently verified. Acts, speakers, and internal headings therefore provide the reference points.

Opening saying: "When the mind is steady, even a clod is a diamond; when the mind wavers, even a diamond is a clod."

Prologue, Stage-Manager: "Every mason tests his mortar before trusting his wall to it."

Act I, Gaṅgeśa: "Does an auspicious invocation actually cause anything?"

Act I, Buddhist: "You have made your causal rule untestable."

Act II, Gaṅgeśa: "This very conch is silver."

Act II, Buddhist: "A newly made pot, before it was fired, was black."

Act III, Gaṅgeśa: "Smoke; therefore fire."

Act III, Disciple: "I have not seen every fire in the world."

Act IV, Buddhist: "What precisely is the subject of this inference?"

Act IV, Gaṅgeśa: "I have refuted my own careless proof."

Act IV, Buddhist: "I still do not say that I am convinced."

Explanatory note: "The analogy or testimony division of this treatise."

Illustrative collection: "Folklore about Gaṅgeśa's childhood."

Illustrative collection: "Devadatta is outside the house."

Illustrative collection: "The identification of broccoli."

Critical Section 5 | Original Chapter −96 — The Preservation of Memory

The printed page range is based on the table of contents; the individual page number of each quotation has not been independently verified.

A regularised Unicode character-group count of the material isolated from Chapter [−96] to the beginning of the following chapter [−95] in the combined original Word text yields 2,231 units. A discrepancy of five units has not been treated as a decisive literary fact; nor have the appendix, the contents, or the exempla at the end of the play been detached from the chapter and assigned elsewhere. To disclose the results of both counting procedures is an elementary obligation of textual criticism.

Accordingly, the temporal units of the drama are distinguished in this critique as the well at dawn, the debating hall during the day, a confidential conversation at night, the return to the well in the evening, and an epilogue set in an indeterminate, remote future. These transitions between scenes, the four acts, the objects onstage, and the narrator's anticipations of the future are the actual grounds of analysis; an outline of a death alone is inadequate here.

At the end of the chapter, a folk account of the naming of Bhāmatī and a commentary on the conch-and-silver illusion appear under the heading "Stories and Illustrations Associated with Vācaspati Miśra." Neither is a newly enacted event within the play. Both form part of the stage-manager's expository compilation at another narrative level. They belong within the original chapter, but must not be counted in the event register as autonomous scenes equivalent to the investigation of Hulāsā's death. Such delimitation preserves the distinction among saga, folk memory, theatre, and classical reinterpretation.

From Philosophical Disputation to the Calamity of Life: A Turning Point after Five Chapters

In Chapter −100, mistaking the conch for silver was a philosophical problem concerning evidence. Chapter −99 considered the continuity of the self, Chapter −98 the cause of the world, and Chapter −97 the precise refinement of the defining criteria of valid knowledge. "The Preservation of Memory" decisively brings these questions down into social action. Here the consequence of someone's mistaken judgement is not an empty hand, but an unidentified cause of a young woman's death and the denial of her name. The reasoning developed in the preceding plays is now tested as a means of critical examination.

The stage-manager himself marks this distinction: in the earlier tale of conch and silver, "no one had died," whereas here "the well is full." The narrative function of this comparison is substantial: it moves from an example of an imagined cognitive error towards the possibility of social violence. Nevertheless, the chapter does not establish that Hulāsā was murdered. Instead, its narrator uses reasoning to resist the premature designation of her death as "suicide." Its ethical urgency rests not in identifying a definite perpetrator, but in acknowledging uncertainty and protecting the duty to pursue justice.

Through this turn, the saga's enduring question—"Whose name will survive?"—becomes concrete. Earlier the dispute concerned the correct naming of an object; here the authority to confer a name is itself contested. A false designation could corrupt the record of the cause of death; failure to record a name could erase Hulāsā's intellectual existence. The suggestion is that philosophical precision in definition is meaningful only when it enters the defence of evidence concerning an excluded person.

The Well at Dawn: The Scene, Initial Information, and the Limits of Knowledge

After the prologue, the dawn mist, broken lamp, and wet palm-leaf manuscript of the first act signify, in order, incomplete visibility, damaged evidence, and a possible final act of writing. Budhuā reports that Hulāsā was found in the well and that the boatmen saw her in the morning. He expresses anguish at his inability to recover her body with his own hands. He does not, however, claim to have witnessed the cause of her death. The limit of direct observation is clear: the location of the body was seen, not the moment of death.

The first dispute between Vācaspati and Karṇapūra is, in fact, about the authoritative naming of the event. Karṇapūra presses for swift funeral rites; Vācaspati asks what evidence justifies the judgement "suicide." A solitary location and the absence of an eyewitness do not establish an act of self-destruction. By the standards of Navya-Nyāya, the proposed property to be proved—a voluntary taking of one's own life—and the reason offered—the isolation of the place—have no demonstrated necessary concomitance. Here the play effectively prevents an illicit movement from an absence of evidence to an affirmative finding of agency.

Village head Ratneśa raises both the village's "peace" and the fear that families will cease sending their daughters to study. This fear has a double social significance. On the one hand there is a genuine risk that education for girls could be curtailed; on the other, that very fear becomes an argument for closing down questions. Vācaspati sets truth against

reputation, but a still more difficult problem remains for the reader: if an educational institution evades investigation out of fear, how can it secure the trust of girls whose safety is at stake? The question demands an institutional response beyond the narrator's moral maxim.

Hulāsā: The Labour and Authorial Rights of an Absent Character

Hulāsā does not speak directly as a living character onstage. Her presence is assembled from Budhuā's memories, a fragmentary sentence on a palm leaf, Karṇapūra's confidential admission, and the stage-manager's subsequent account. This arrangement is essential to understanding an absent protagonist: the story centres upon someone who can no longer speak in her own defence. Readers must infer her wishes through the voices of others, and the ethics of precisely that mediation forms the chapter's subject.

Budhuā recalls a previous statement of Hulāsā's: had she been accepted as a pupil, her writing would have been respected; instead she was treated as a servant. The technical labour of writing and the ownership of knowledge part company here. A copyist makes a book readable, but prestige accumulates around the commentator's name. Her situation, marked by class and gender, is not simply material for pathos: it provides primary evidence of whom an institution recognises as a producer of knowledge.

The direct instance of denying her a name becomes clear in Karṇapūra's confession in Act III: Hulāsā had wanted to place her own name on her commentary, but permission had been refused. This is an instance of authorial identity being restricted through social power. Even so, the refusal does not determine the cause of her death. Literary criticism must draw a firm line between structural humiliation, possible psychological anguish, and the legal or event-level question of causation.

"I…": An Incomplete Palm Leaf, the Reader's Blank Space, and an Absent Voice

In Act II the last written characters on the palm leaf are "I…" A broken line following this brief word is the most densely charged visual mark in the drama. It is not necessarily a suicide note, a record made at the moment of death, or the name of someone responsible. It is an incomplete inscription whose date of composition, purpose, and reason for interruption remain unknown. To fill the gap to suit the narrative's demands without accepting those limits would be another appropriation of Hulāsā's suppressed voice.

Vāmadeva raises the question of a trustworthy speaker (āpta), and Vācaspati defends the value of a dead person's words. In the play he says that words written privately for oneself are free of deceit, "because deception always

requires an audience." The ethical impulse is powerful, but the epistemological rule is too broad. Even in private writing, one may harbour self-deception, imperfect recollection, or a deliberately fabricated belief; privacy alone does not establish certain trustworthiness. The character's compassion and the evidentiary force of his argument must be examined separately.

In Act IV Budhuā asks Vācaspati to complete "I…"; Vācaspati refuses. That refusal shows greater ethical maturity than the hesitation of Act I. Neither writer nor scholar has the right to fix the intention of a dead person by the power of their own intellect. Leaving a blank space blank becomes a genuine test of the reader's receptivity. The unfinished sentence is not simply a source of frustration: it becomes a structural memorial to the irreparability of a socially silenced voice.

Verbal Testimony, Absence, Inference, and "Cause Unknown"

A technical examination of evidence distinguishes three claims: the body was found in the well; Hulāsā's palm-leaf text is incomplete; and the cause of death was suicide. The first may be supported by direct observation, and the second by inspecting the damaged manuscript; the third requires an independent causal chain. Karṇapūra's move to a conclusion is inconclusive because the solitary site is consistent with suicide, accident, and crime alike. Without establishing a necessary connection with one particular alternative, suspension of judgement is appropriate.

Vācaspati challenges Karṇapūra's claim that a woman's testimony has lesser value. He argues that the validity of evidence should be determined not by the speaker's lineage but by the soundness of the means through which knowledge arises. The theatrical force of the declaration is evident: it opposes the unjustified demand that social rank be an independent measure of truth. Nevertheless, it would be wrong to treat the character's attribution of women's exclusion to "Mīmāṃsā doctrine" as the universally accepted or uniquely authenticated rule of historical Mīmāṃsā. The dialogue is an ideological representation within a modern Maithili dramatic narrative, not a verified quotation from an ancient legal code.

The decision to record "Cause unknown" gives narrative form to a caution associated with the analysis of absence in Navya-Nyāya. Not knowing the cause is not equivalent to "there is no cause"; likewise, "suicide has not been proved" is not equivalent to "murder has been proved." Yet simply writing "undetermined" does not complete an inquiry. There is still a need for procedures to gather evidence, inspect Hulāsā's earlier records and the body, and examine potential witnesses. The play makes a strong ethical case for withholding judgement but does not develop a detailed practical method of investigation.

Act III: Confidential Admission, Dramatic Irony, and an Ethical Failure

In the third act the night scene moves the action from the public dispute of the first two acts to a private moral predicament. Before the village head, Karṇapūra recounts an event three months earlier: Hulāsā had been forbidden to put her name on her commentary. This information is not part of the public hearing before Vācaspati and the members of the assembly. Budhuā, seated unseen in the shadows, overhears it. The reader and the hidden listener therefore acquire knowledge whose public verification is still outstanding. The unequal distribution of narrative knowledge creates palpable tension.

Karṇapūra moves towards acknowledging the wrongness of his refusal, yet decides not to admit it publicly; he promises not to bar a woman's name in future. This is not complete repentance but a partial reform that also protects himself. The facile attribution of criminal guilt must be avoided: Karṇapūra admits denying an authorial right, but does not know the cause of the death. The social consequences of the humiliation produced by his fear are conceivable; nevertheless, to make that act the certain and sole cause of Hulāsā's death would be an excess of inference.

Budhuā hears the conversation but says nothing at the time. For the reader, that silence generates a difficult question: if he has witnessed this admission, why does he not immediately bring it to Vācaspati? Grief, fear, or dramatic compression may account for it, but the original text offers no explicit motivation. This omitted action leaves a small but genuine looseness in the causal chain. The gap in the transmission of evidence must remain visible to criticism even amid the solemn language of the promise.

Act IV: Inscription in Stone, the Incompleteness of Memory, and the Difference from Justice

In the evening Vācaspati declares that the stone should be inscribed: "Cause unknown, but her name was Hulāsā, and justice remains to be done." Three different temporal elements meet in the inscription. "Cause unknown" marks the limits of present knowledge; "her name was Hulāsā" recognises a person who existed in the past; and "justice remains" signifies an unfinished obligation to the future. This triad of knowledge, memory, and ethical promise within one public record is a significant literary achievement.

The stone, however, is neither an official investigation nor a systematic record of testimony. Questions concerning the event remain unresolved. It would therefore be mistaken to call the memorial a judicial solution. Karṇapūra's private admission, the history of denying authorial rights, Hulāsā's unfinished letter, and the possibility of homicide belong to

separate evidentiary categories. To some extent the play itself acknowledges this separation through the words "justice remains."

Budhuā challenges the apparatus of logic: what is the use of philosophy if it cannot preserve the name of a poor copyist's daughter? This is more than a pragmatic question about the utility of knowledge; it concerns its social ownership. The labour of producing knowledge goes unrecognised while the prestige of knowledge attaches to the name of an elite teacher; the intellectual institution therefore faces a public ethical test. Vācaspati entrusts the work of preserving memory to Budhuā. Yet the authority of knowledge and the labour of remembrance are once again separated, with the latter laid on a servant's shoulders. The honour of this new responsibility also repeats a social inequality.

From Budhuā to Burhba: Deep Time, Temporal Expansion, and Anticipation

The recollection of Budhuā's thirty years of service first locates the character within the span of a human lifetime. In Act IV he vows to stand witness "as long as even one name continues to be erased by injustice." The promise reaches beyond the likely life of one person. In the epilogue the stage-manager briefly says that the old servant came to be known as "Burhba" and departed with the conch and rope towards the emerging monastery of Udayanācārya. Narrative duration expands from the brief scene of a plausible human life to the epochal rhythm of a saga.

Anticipatory phrases such as "seated on a single branch for twelve hundred years" are not necessarily direct evidence of a miraculous event in the story world. They also compress the time of a long narrative tradition and of oral legend. Some readers may understand them as the rules of a non-natural narrative; others as the name or memory handed from one generation to another. The original text withholds a definitive interpretation here. Without examining Chapter –90 or the much later events at Channa Gachhi, it would be inappropriate to impose one final meaning.

Budhuā's departure between the traditions associated with the life of Vācaspati Miśra and the monastery of Udayanācārya also suggests a modern recombination of temporalities. The actual contemporaneity of the named historical figures is not demonstrated; the writer joins different historical strata to make a saga of folk memory. Criticism must keep historical sequence separate from the invented chronology of the novel. The play's truth is not an external claim that "Burhba's ordinary body lived for fourteen centuries," but its narrative transformation of unfinished justice into a responsibility spanning generations.

Chronology, Changes of Setting, and a Measurement of Narrative Distance

The sequence of scenes across the day is not entirely linear. Act I takes place at dawn, Act II by day, Act III at night, and Act IV in the evening. Unless the evening of Act IV belongs to the following day, there is an unannounced reversal of time. The play does not clarify the relationship between this night and evening. This is a specific chronological inconsistency that could have been resolved by a brief indication such as "the following evening." The criticism regards it as relatively minor against the larger significance of the story, but nevertheless demonstrable.

The spatial movement, by contrast, is orderly: beside the well, inside the debating hall, outside the entrance, and back to the well. The movement between an interior institutional stage and an exterior site of labour symbolises a redistribution of the centre of knowledge. Within the debating hall, the method of proof is discussed; outside it, the suffering of a servant and the denial of a name test its consequences. The well is a natural site of water, but the scene also makes it a centre of unknown violence, obstructed speech, and prolonged waiting.

At the end of the drama, the stage-manager traverses many years in a brief passage of informational prose: reactions to girls' education, the subsequent recording of women's names, Vācaspati's death, and Budhuā's change of name and identity. In Genette's distinctions of duration, this resembles rapid summary, whereas the first four acts exhibit the pace of scene and dialogue. The later reference to Channa Gachhi is an anticipation of the future, but its exact fulfilment cannot be asserted without examining subsequent chapters of the actual text.

Narrator, Focalisation, and Leaps Between Narrative Levels

The stage-manager asks the immediate audience to "look and examine for yourselves." This invitation attempts to turn readers into examiners of evidence instead of passive endorsers of a moral position. In the first two acts, focalisation remains within the range of information publicly available to the characters. In the third, the reader accompanies Budhuā as he overhears a secret conversation. In the epilogue, the stage-manager presents a more comprehensive knowledge of collective consequences over many years. These changes cannot be adequately captured by simply classifying everything under an unchanging omniscient narrator.

The placement of Karṇapūra and Budhuā in Act III is particularly effective: Karṇapūra speaks, the village head listens, Budhuā is the unseen witness, and the reader becomes a privileged auditor of the concealed exchange. The distribution of who knows how much creates the plot's moral

intensity. In Act IV, however, Budhuā does not pass this confidential information on to Vācaspati. Narrative suspense survives, but a possible avenue of investigation is blocked. The conflict between narrative effect and procedural coherence needs to be acknowledged.

"Stories and Illustrations Associated with Vācaspati Miśra," following the drama, constitutes a further explanatory level within the stage-manager's narrative. The folk tradition about the naming of Bhāmatī becomes a parallel emblem of Hulāsā's forgotten labour. Yet a folk account, a statement by a dramatic character, and the documented life of the historical Vācaspati belong to different categories. Readers should not be led to confuse dialogue placed in a character's mouth with evidence for scholarly history.

Women's Representation, Manuscript Rights, and Excluded Communities

Hulāsā's labour consists in copying and transmitting knowledge, but she is not recognised as its owner. Her insistence upon writing her own name in opposition to anonymous designations such as "written by" amounts to a primary resistance in the domain of authorial rights. From the standpoint of Videha's parallel history, the issue is who receives recognition for the writing, copying, editing, and dissemination of books. A conventional history centred upon teachers preserves the philosopher's name; Hulāsā's desire exposes the incompleteness of such a history.

Karṇapūra seeks to protect the community's "prestige," the village head the acceptance of the school, Vācaspati truth, and Budhuā the name. Hulāsā herself remains silent amid these four positions. Criticism of social injustice may sometimes restore the victim's right to speech, but it may also make her merely the emblem of a male rescuer's decision. In this drama, her incomplete sentence is preserved—a major achievement—while her living conversation and the complexity of her desires receive little development—a significant limitation.

Budhuā is a servant rather than an institutionally authorised teacher of logic, yet his question becomes an authoritative centre of judgement. This is a positive attempt to regard a labouring community as a source of moral intelligence. Nevertheless, the actual boatmen, Hulāsā's female companions, other girls working as copyists, and potential witnesses of the death do not receive independent development onstage. Polyphony here is in its early stages, not an extensive documentary recreation of diverse social testimonies.

Water, Lamp, Conch, Palm Leaf, and Stone: The Meaning of the Object-System

The well's water is not merely the background of an additional event: it is the site of an unexplained death and an incomplete recovery. The wet palm leaf signifies the material vulnerability of knowledge, while the broken lamp denotes a failure of institutional protection. In Act IV a new small lamp is lit. This is not a complete solution, but a sign that vigilant guardianship has begun amid grief. The meaning of the scenic arrangement develops from this point: every object conveys not the perfection of the teacher's logic but the reality of justice delayed.

The conch was the object of cognitive illusion in the earlier chapter; here it becomes a token of Budhuā's thirty years of service and his long witnessing. The transformation of the image establishes a sustained intertextual connection. The palm leaf is private, fragile, and unfinished; the stone public, durable, and plainly inscribed. Yet uncertainty persists between them: the inscription cannot reveal the cause of death. This qualitative distinction grounds the chapter's title, "The Preservation of Memory." Producing a written record of remembrance is not the same as a complete inquiry into the truth.

From an environmental perspective, water and earth furnish images of the longevity of names. Budhuā describes his vow as "the work of the tree, the water, and the darkness"; nature becomes an allegorical custodian of memory. In this particular chapter, however, there is little developed depiction of water systems, the social uses of the well, pollution, flooding, or environmental damage. It is more faithful to the evidence to regard these as anticipations of later environment-centred chapters than to declare the present chapter a complete ecological narrative.

The Standards of Dhvani, Rasa, Vakrokti, and Aucitya

The opening saying sets bodily dissolution against the endurance of a name. The folk song extends this contrast into a communal voice: a king may burn books but cannot erase a name lodged in people's throats. Hulāsā's death and Budhuā's grief provide the basis for karuṇa-rasa; the heroic disposition finds expression in the vow to preserve names. No completed tranquillity of śānta-rasa is achieved, for "justice remains" is the concluding awareness. Several aesthetic dispositions operate here; the story does not settle into a single emotion.

The phrase "the well is full" places a frightening reality against the philosophical illusion of the earlier chapter. Vakrokti also emerges in Vācaspati's insistence that completing the dead woman's unfinished sentence would dishonour her memory. The inscription "Cause unknown"

carries the suggestion not of the scholar's triumph but of acknowledged ignorance. The aesthetic implication differs from a plainly stated lesson: it affects the reader through the persistence of emptiness.

A question of appropriateness arises especially in the epilogue. The play itself depicts an open investigation, but the stage-manager announces the stone's long memory, later reforms in the naming of women, and Budhuā's journey within a single compressed passage. Some future social consequences therefore appear to become available a little too easily. If the drama insists upon unresolved suffering, it would be more convincing to develop the process of institutional reform arising out of injustice in scenes as well.

Classical Intertext and the Folk Account of the Naming of *Bhāmatī*

The play draws upon the tradition of Vācaspati Miśra's name but does not claim to be a historically reconstructed biography. The later folk account of how Bhāmatī received its name associates the reputation of a book with the unacknowledged service of a woman. This offers a parallel to Hulāsā's desire to place her name upon a commentary: in one account a husband eventually gives a text his wife's name; in the other, a girl who copies manuscripts is denied the right to name her own work. The comparison deepens the ethical question of the recognition of women's labour.

The historical truth of the Bhāmatī folk account cannot, however, be established from the text of this novel alone. What the stage-manager relates as oral tradition may function as a narrative symbol or as a source of social belief, not as a specific fact of biographical history. The critic must distinguish the words of original Nyāya or Advaita writings from the modern author's creative interpretation. The classical importance of Vācaspati Miśra does not automatically turn the dialogue attributed to him into scriptural evidence.

The later commentary on conch and silver reinterprets the first chapter: correcting the mistaken identification of an object is not enough; one must also correct the misidentification of a death and the mistaken judgements of society. This intertextuality is an internal creative rereading, not an assertion that the traditional treatises are interchangeable. Indian epistemology enters into conversation with social justice, but their procedures remain distinct. Conflating logical validity, moral obligation, and judicial inquiry would blur the criticism's analytic categories.

A Causal Map of Events and Cognitive Density

A count of the principal changes in the scenes yields seven analytic points: the report that Hulāsā's body has been found in the well; Karṇapūra's

haste; Vācaspati's refusal to reach a conclusion; the incomplete writing on the palm leaf; Karṇapūra's confidential admission that he had denied Hulāsā her name; the decision to make an inscription; and Budhuā's vow to bear witness across generations. These are units of critical analysis, not a final statistical measure of "events per thousand words." Each changes a state of evidence, decision, or social relations.

The causal sequence contains a particularly important gap. Hulāsā died, but the manner of death is not disclosed. Karṇapūra denied her the right to a name three months earlier, but it has not been demonstrated that this act caused her death. Budhuā overheard a confidential exchange but did not turn it into public testimony. Instead of praising artificial density on the basis of "seven events," it is therefore essential to identify causes, evidence, absent alternatives, and the unresolved character of the ending.

Most of the action is active as question and answer despite the restricted physical movement onstage. Several transformations are cognitive: the meaning of solitude changes; the status of the letter changes; private knowledge grows; and a name is given durable written recognition. The chapter's density consequently lies neither in the spectacle of external violence nor in the mere number of action verbs, but in the tension between evidence, authority, and judgement.

Verified Analytical Table: Act, Event, Evidence, and Limitation

Scene and time	Principal event or information	Change in knowledge or decision	Gap or critical question
Prologue: dawn	The stage-manager contrasts the earlier conch-silver error with a question of death	The social test of reasoning begins	The narrator does not know the cause of death
Act I: the well	Budhuā reports; Karṇapūra concludes suicide	Vācaspati prevents a conclusion without evidence	No eyewitness; the reason is inconclusive
Act II: debate hall	The unfinished words "I …"; Vāmadeva's question about verbal testimony	Public insistence on recording the cause as unknown	Time and intention of the writing uncertain
Act III: night	Karṇapūra admits an earlier denial of a woman's name	Reader and Budhuā gain knowledge	Admission does not prove murder; Budhuā remains silent
Act IV: evening	Inscription of a name on stone; Budhuā's pledge	Safeguarding memory becomes an ethical duty	Investigation of the alleged offence remains incomplete
Epilogue: later years	Response to women's education; Karṇapūra's reform; the name Burhba	A long-term public narrative develops	Process of reform compressed; folklore is not history
After the drama	Bhāmatī oral tradition and reinterpretation of conch and silver	Thematic echoes of female labour and error	Neither stage occurrence nor historical proof

Testing Institutional Credibility and Narrative Limits

Three questions are particularly difficult from a critical standpoint. First, after Hulāsā's body is found, the drama does not develop a medical or community-witness examination of its condition. Second, Vācaspati offers a very generous reading of the fragment "I...," although ultimately he denies his right to complete it. Third, Budhuā remains silent after hearing the confidential admission, without a clear motive. At these points, the play creates forceful ethical dilemmas but falls short of the causal strictness of a fully worked investigation narrative.

A fourth limitation is the speed of social reform. Karṇapūra eventually keeps his promise and more women copyists receive recognition. This is not impossible, but the rules of the educational institution, resistance from other teachers, Hulāsā's colleagues, and the collective actions of women receive little development in scenes. A complex structure of social power is more obdurate than one individual's repentance. The issue is especially important under the tests of Videha's parallel history, where historical transformation cannot be explained solely by the decisions of great men.

Yet the play's ethical achievement is clear. Vācaspati does not invent a certain criminal in order to earn a reward for solving a mystery; he records ignorance and keeps the respect due to a name independent of an uncertain inquiry. Acknowledging the limits of truth imposes a more demanding responsibility on the reader than a facile revelation. "Justice remains" is no convenient closed ending; the demand that justice should not be indefinitely postponed under the pretext of preserving social memory survives.

The Chapter's Value, Limits, and Critical Relation to the Trilogy

"The Preservation of Memory" offers an experiential test of the four philosophical opening chapters of the prehistory. Having passed through misidentification of objects, disputes about the self, inference about the creator, and the definition of evidence, the novel demonstrates why safeguarding the name of a powerless person in history is so difficult. Hulāsā's unfinished writing is central to this transformation. The drama's strength is that it does not use the author's omniscient imagination to supply evidence that is missing; it keeps the matter partly open.

Its principal critical limitations are the possible yet unproved relation between social pressure and the death, the failure to use private testimony, and the extremely compressed account of change across generations at the end. Identifying these limitations does not disparage the work's pathos or social purpose; it tests that purpose by the standard of evidence. By this criterion the chapter demonstrates the potential to become a more densely

developed social narrative than the preceding declarative philosophical plays.

Before moving to Chapter –95, "The Waterlogged Manuscript," one question must be preserved: amid what material, social, and natural obstructions can the inscribed name and the incomplete palm leaf survive? "The Preservation of Memory" does not yet give a full answer; it lays the foundation for examining characters, labour, water, writing, and the institutions of testimony. The connections proposed here require confirmation or revision through scrutiny of the actual next chapter.

Chapter –96: Concise Index of Evidence Verified against the Original

The following excerpts were checked verbatim against Chapter [–96] of the combined original Word manuscript. The range 88–99 is the printed page range given by the original contents, not an independently verified page number for any particular quotation; act and speaker are therefore identified.

Opening saying: "The body returns to earth; the name remains upon the leaf."

Prologue, stage-manager: "No one died there; only the hand was left empty."

Act I, Budhuā: "Today I could not bring her out."

Act I, Budhuā recalling Hulāsā: "If I had been accepted as a pupil …"

Act I, Vācaspati: "On what evidence do you know that she fell in herself?"

Act I, Vācaspati: "Evidence of absence establishes absence alone, not agency."

Act II, palm leaf: "The final word is unfinished—'I…'."

Act II, Vāmadeva: "Is a dead person's last letter evidence, or merely a token of memory?"

Act II, Vācaspati: "Deception always requires an audience."

Act II, Vācaspati: "Cause unknown."

Act III, Karṇapūra: "A woman's name does not befit a treatise."

Act III, Karṇapūra: "I will remain silent."

Act IV, stone inscription: "Cause unknown, but her name was Hulāsā, and justice remains."

Act IV, Vācaspati: "We shall leave the incompleteness as it is."

Act IV, Budhuā: "The work of trees, water, and darkness."

Epilogue, stage-manager: “The ‘old servant’ became ‘Burhba’.”

Later illustration: “The folk account of the naming of Bhāmatī.”

Critical Section 6 | Original Chapter −95 — The Waterlogged Manuscript

Individual printed page numbers for the quotations have not been verified; references are therefore provided by act, speaker, and scene.

The Actual Chapter Boundary and the Central Critical Question

Ninety-five textual paragraph lines occur between the heading of Chapter [−95] and the position immediately preceding the heading of Chapter [−94] in the combined original Word text. A separate regularised Unicode character-group count yields 1,716 units. A difference of one unit has not been treated as evidence of a textual revision or an additional event. The count includes headings, names of speakers, stage directions, and philosophical examples; these units should not be equated with average printed words.

The primary test is whether water and earth merely form the scenery or actually motivate events. Here the immediate catastrophe is not a flood but a fire in the monastery's manuscript room at night, followed by the use of a pond as an improvised refuge for the books. The "flood" of the title's associations and the folk song connects the event to a general environmental memory; it would nevertheless be a false synopsis of the staged action to say that "the manuscript was carried off in a flood."

The main play and the "Stories and Illustrations Associated with Udayanācārya" following it belong to separate narrative levels. The account of the absence of an invocation in Kiraṇāvalī and the story of Udayanācārya and Jagannātha are related by the stage-manager after the play ends. They must not be counted as direct events occurring during the night of Jīvantī's death. The structural distinction matters equally to historical interpretation: imagined dialogue, traditional folklore, and an authenticated classical text are not documents of the same kind.

A Causal Bridge from the Previous Chapter: From Hulāsā's Name to Jīvantī's Name

The main ethical consequence of Chapter −96, "The Preservation of Memory," was Budhuā's vow to prevent Hulāsā's name from disappearing. In the prologue of "The Waterlogged Manuscript," the stage-manager says that Budhuā has travelled beyond Vācaspati's commemorative stone to Udayanācārya's monastery in another part of Mithila, and that Jīvantī is his pupil. The journey is not simply a change of location for a character: an obligation to remember, born in one place, enters a different institution.

In the preceding chapter, the unfinished "I…" on a palm leaf crystallised a crisis of the right to write. Here a living person risks her life in the labour of protecting manuscripts. In both chapters, an unequal distribution of prestige governs the writing and preservation of institutional books. Yet the composition cannot claim that both deaths arose from the same cause. Hulāsā's cause of death was deliberately kept unknown in the earlier play; Jīvantī's disappearance occurs in an enacted scene of danger. Unless this narratological distinction is retained, the sequence of events in the prehistory becomes excessively simple.

Budhuā's advanced age, trembling hands, and failing eyesight, set against Jīvantī's swimming ability, generate a genuine situation of alternatives. The labour of guarding memory passes from an elderly servant to a young female pupil, but there is no corresponding institutional division of responsibility and safety. Her courage in choosing an action must be recognised; glorifying it as a great sacrifice while forgetting deficiencies in training, equipment, assistance, and safety planning would be inappropriate.

The Sequence of Four Acts: Major Changes and the Consequences of Subplots

In Act I, the news that the lamp-stand has fallen becomes an actual disturbance caused by fire. The flames spread, and three important bundles remain inside. Udayanācārya acknowledges that the fire prevents him from going in. Jīvantī suggests wrapping the manuscripts in oil-treated cloth and securing them in the pond. Budhuā warns her about crocodiles, but she invokes her swimming ability in making the decision. At this point the character's choice and her assessment of risk become the causal elements of the event.

Act II deepens the scene beside the pond. Jīvantī regards the shallow bank as unsuitable and goes towards the middle, keeps the bundles raised, says that her hair is caught among the roots, and finally loses her voice. Budhuā leaps in to rescue her but does not find her; the bundle remains in his hands. Her disappearance is an event directly presented onstage, but the text never directly depicts her being seized by a crocodile. Therefore "a crocodile killed her" is not an established plot fact of this chapter.

In Act III, Śambhunātha initially expresses delight that the manuscript has been preserved; Udayanācārya makes Jīvantī's absence the central ethical question. Someśvara returns to the question of an auspicious invocation. Udayanācārya acknowledges that his earlier statement was incomplete and directs that a record of remembrance be made. In Act IV, Budhuā and Udayana move from ritual to rules governing institutions; the epilogue summarises the destruction of the memorial chamber and the new life of

the story in folk tradition. The dramatic climax is the night incident in the pond; the intellectual climax occurs in the morning assembly.

"Fire in the Manuscript Room": Accident, Choice, and the Structure of Safety

The chapter makes the immediate origin of the fire clear: after a lamp-stand falls, the curtain in a rear room catches fire. This accident is not merely a sign of destiny. It raises underlying questions about the placement of lamps, storage arrangements, and preparation against fire. The play does not, however, pursue this administrative chain of causation in depth. If three bundles were left inside, alternative means of securing them—fire-resistant coverings, a collective retrieval attempt, relocating them near the exit, or using vessels of water—are not examined. Jīvantī's chosen course thus advances the plot but does not constitute a comprehensive treatment of decision-making under risk.

Udayanācārya rules out entering the fire himself. Jīvantī devises her own alternative, while the other pupils have already fled carrying bundles. The succession of decisions creates an extraordinary inequality of labour: deliberation by the institution's senior or principal authority is closed, while a young female pupil's body enters the area of danger. The original does not state Jīvantī's caste, so it would be improper to invent that specific identity and draw conclusions from it. Her position as a female pupil and the low prestige accorded the work of service are nevertheless clear.

The stage directions concerning a lamp that "is shaking more and more" and the reference to flooding in the introductory saying can be read as anticipatory signs. The movement of the lamp is not itself an adequate causal explanation for the fire; it is a device that puts the audience on alert. A small act involving the fire suddenly changes a philosophical drama into a drama of survival. The experience of time changes: earlier there was ample room to discuss the auspicious opening, whereas now emergency time is measured by questions such as "How many bundles are left?"

The Pond: Non-Human Agency, Environment, and the Uncertain Presence of Crocodiles

The pond is not an inert natural image in this chapter. Its depth, shallow margin, roots, darkness, moving water, and possible crocodiles constrain the characters' choices. Jīvantī considers the shallow margin unsafe for the manuscripts; Budhuā advises her not to enter the middle; her hair becoming caught among roots arrests her movement. The non-human world has an unmistakably active role in this causal sequence. In this sense of environmental narrative, the pond becomes indispensable to the occurrence of events.

Yet the limits of non-human agency in the text must be respected. Budhuā says there is an old crocodile in the pond; Jīvantī says that "something moved" underwater; later she reports that her hair has become entangled in roots. The text never identifies a direct crocodile attack, a bite, or a cause of death. The possibility of a crocodile is effective as environmental danger and as an anticipation of the larger title, but assigning a definite biological act to an unresolved event would amount to inventing evidence.

This uncertainty gives rise to the long-term image of Jal Samadhi Among the Crocodiles: the crocodile becomes not merely an animal, but a possible centre of unknown aquatic danger, invisible crisis, and legendary memory. Symbolic elaboration cannot substitute for facts about actual aquatic life or behaviour. A major environmental-critical question is that the event emerges from a conjunction of defective human safety planning, institutional insistence, and the pond's physical dangers. It would be unjust to erase human responsibility by calling the episode simply "the cruelty of nature."

The Title "The Waterlogged Manuscript" and the Contradiction in the Scenic Object

The title gives the reader an image of a submerged book. The folk song likewise conjures the imagined picture of pages sinking into water and ink dissolving. In Act II, however, Jīvantī clearly says, "The bundle is above the water; it has not sunk." After her disappearance, the bundle is recovered safely. On one level, this opposition may be deliberate irony: the human being is submerged, while the books for whose protection she entered the water survive intact.

On another level, a material inconsistency remains between title, announced plan, and action. Jīvantī initially proposes to "submerge" the bundles in the pond, then insists that they not become wet; the waterproofing of oil-treated cloth and the physical distance between the burning building and the reservoir are not established. Criticism should neither pardon this discrepancy automatically under the name of metaphor nor condemn the entire passage merely because of a problem in physical coherence. The effectiveness of stagecraft and causal realism demand separate evaluation.

"The book grew wet, but the song remained dry" is not a statement about an event; it is the generalised formulation of the folk song. At this point its suggestion shifts: whether books survive or perish, oral transmission offers another means of protecting memory. The story performs the inverse action, saving the manuscript while allowing its guardian to disappear beneath the water. This inversion complicates the song's general

reassurance and shifts the play's ethical centre from protecting books towards protecting human beings.

Jīvantī's Agency and the Ethical Double Meaning of Sacrifice

Jīvantī is not merely a passive victim. She proposes the plan, recognises elderly Budhuā's physical limitations, describes her own ability to swim, and makes the decision to accept danger. Her agency—her capacity for self-directed action—is visible in both words and deeds. Yet this freedom operates within an institution where the possibility immediately arises of placing the manuscript above the living female servant. Voluntary action does not abolish institutional responsibility.

At the moment of danger Budhuā cries, "Let go of the bundle; think of yourself!" But Jīvantī refuses. The scene generates a tension between courage and a potentially self-destructive loyalty to the institution. Sanctifying a woman's sacrifice cannot become a way of avoiding social criticism of the neglect of her safety. A responsive reader can recognise the dignity of Jīvantī's decision while asking why the monastery provided no adequate assistant, rope, lighting, equipment, or coordinated rescue.

Jīvantī's last unfinished utterance, "To bear witness for books is also…," risks being turned, in the light of her death, into a martyr's manifesto. She speaks at a moment of crisis; the sentence is never completed. To complete it as the doctrine of an institution would be another unauthorised appropriation of her silence. The lesson of Hulāsā's case in Chapter –96 is precisely this: an unfinished utterance should be respected rather than filled in with a conjectured intention. Udayana expressly draws this parallel in the present chapter, although he does not explore all the alternatives available to Jīvantī's incomplete decision.

Someśvara's Question: Auspicious Invocation and the Fallacy of Measuring Success

In Act I the disciple Someśvara asks why a major work such as Kiraṇāvalī lacks an auspicious opening. Udayana replies that care, study, lucid writing, and timely revision constitute his auspicious practice; a work successfully completed without obstruction is evidence of its success. The meaning of "without obstruction" in this initial claim is ambiguous: does it mean that the author completed the manuscript, or that no ethical harm occurred in the whole process? The calamity of the night makes that ambiguity tangible.

In the morning Someśvara returns to the earlier statement: the manuscript survived, but a life was lost—how, then, can the work have been completed without obstruction? An external event forces the revision of an intellectual proposition. Here lies the play's most effective cognitive

turning point, for the teacher-pupil relation ceases to be a matter of traditional obedience. The pupil holds his teacher answerable for his previous words. Udayana accepts the incompleteness of his answer. Instead of diminishing the protagonist's standing, the admission increases his ethical credibility.

In terms drawn from Navya-Nyāya, the earlier proposal treated the reason "a book completed without obstruction" as establishing the property "successful composition," while omitting a limiting condition: the question of the total human cost and the safety of the means used. The original literary dialogue does not offer a formal five-member syllogism, but its sequence clearly displays a revision attentive to limiting conditions. We must not evade the problem by mistaking moral judgement for a formal Nyāya theorem. The transformation is a matter of modern dramatic ethics.

The Morning Institutional Assembly: Śambhunātha's Scales and the Politics of Names

In the morning, the head of the monastery, Śambhunātha, first expresses satisfaction that the manuscript has been saved. Udayana asks whether Śambhunātha first counted the books or thought of Jīvantī. Śambhunātha's following designation of her as a "female pupil-servant" exposes an economy of prestige. An institutional system that accords a book value for a thousand years but treats a woman's life as a transient utility makes human loss seem ordinary.

Udayana's metaphor of the scales is forceful, but it is not a complete alternative to judicial judgement. What immediate responsibility will the monastery assume for a living worker's death? Who will investigate the fire? What safety arrangements will be made in the face of earlier warnings about the pond? Evidence of long-term changes in Śambhunātha's authority or in the institution's rules is limited. Udayana's immediate ethical sharpness is an achievement of the composition, but reform in an individual's conduct is not a substitute for institutional safety reform.

The inequality of dialogue also deserves examination. Śambhunātha largely becomes an embodiment of moral error; he is given little room to argue his own position at length. Udayana's criticism may be justified, but the opponent's complexity remains restricted by the standards of polyphony. Such a device increases dramatic clarity while reducing the opportunity to explore the actual relations of power, income, labour division, and decision-making within the institution.

Budhuā's Witness Across Two Generations: The Reliability of Memory

Budhuā is now old, carrying the memory of Hulāsā from the previous chapter. His presence when Jīvantī disappears in the night, his attempt to rescue her, and his failure make him not simply a narrator but a person directly afflicted by the event. The unfinished palm-leaf writing of one generation meets the broken utterance of another. This is not a mechanical repetition of the story's material, but a recurrence of memory generated by fresh loss.

In Act III Budhuā quotes Vācaspati's old teaching. In Act IV Udayana says that Budhuā mutters Hulāsā's unfinished words in his sleep, and that he has heard him do so on three nights. This disclosure grants the reader indirect access to Budhuā's inner world, though it does not come through Budhuā's own immediate account. It also creates a slight tension concerning privacy: Udayana learns about the old man's private grief from his unknowing murmurs, then makes that knowledge the basis of dialogue.

Budhuā's question, "Will the list never end?", gives voice to a central concern of the extended saga. If institutions continue to erase the names of those who protect their texts, the memorial chamber will keep filling up. But if merely recording names is taken to constitute reform, the process leading to these deaths may continue unchanged. Keeping the chain of witnesses alive and preventing the death of the next pupil are different obligations. The chapter achieves emotional success with the first question; it is partly silent about the second.

The Unfinished Utterances: Hulāsā's "I…" and Jīvantī's "To Bear Witness for Books…"

The formal parallel between Hulāsā's unfinished "I…" on the palm leaf and Jīvantī's broken words in the water, "To bear witness for books is also…," is explicitly established. Both women lose the completion of their own speech, while male characters, institutions, and the stage-manager subsequently deliberate over its meaning. This narrative structure places the victims at the centre of the story but keeps their ultimate intentions invisible.

The two gaps, however, are not evidence of the same kind. Hulāsā's palm leaf is a written object whose date and purpose remain doubtful; Jīvantī's unfinished utterance belongs to a directly enacted moment of speech cut short during a crisis. The first entails a documentary absence of knowledge; the second is an abrupt interruption in the duration of a direct utterance.

Udayana's analogy is emotionally effective, but scholarly analysis must retain the difference between the sources.

Budhuā says that love and justice begin where a sentence is not completed. The line is a concentrated principle of the novel's narrative ethics: filling a character's silence with whatever is convenient can amount to an abuse of authorial omniscience. Yet there is a converse danger in dissolving silence into the beauty of mystery if investigation, rescue, responsibility, and corrective action remain unanswered.

The Chamber of Memory: Archive, Memorial, and Counter-Institutional History

Udayana declares that the names of those who guard books—pupil, servant, or woman—shall be written in the chamber of memory. This is presented as a rule against anonymity imposed on grounds of caste, gender, or rank. In Act I Jīvantī says, "I merely bind the leaves"; later Udayana declares that this very labour of preservation deserves recognition in a public record. Here the politics of naming is not abstract benevolence; it is a proposed change in institutional documentation.

Under the criteria of Videha's parallel history, such preservation matters because established bibliographies retain the names of authors and philosophers while the workers who copy, protect, bind, maintain libraries, and clean every day are often lost. The narrative questions this invisibility. Nevertheless, this fictional drama cannot establish archival facts about a historical monastery, an ancient catalogue, or Udayanācārya's life. The "chamber of memory" is an institutional proposal within the story world.

Another problem remains: Jīvantī's name receives prestige after death, but the chapter does not sufficiently establish how far her intellectual rights, remuneration, participation in decisions, or safety had been recognised while she lived. There is profound beauty in the assertion that folk song survives after the memorial has been destroyed; yet the immortality of memory cannot compensate for the loss of the named person's life. Historical criticism and poetic compassion must both find a place here.

The Evidentiary Status of Folk Song: The Human Voice versus the Book

The opening saying and song repeatedly declare that water can submerge a book but not the human voice. This is not a claim of literal indestructibility but an optimistic suggestion about the endurance of communal memory. The voice itself is mortal. If the community changes, the language fragments, or the oral tradition breaks, the song too can be

forgotten. The metaphor's human importance should be acknowledged without treating it as an axiom of history.

At the chapter's close, the chamber of memory is destroyed, the manuscript house is ruined, and Jīvantī changes from the "water-maiden" to "Panidubbi" in the names used by the community. This transformation has several levels: the original name is partly effaced by the folk name, while the death survives in the communal mythology of danger and rescue. To call the transformation an unambiguous victory because "the name survived" would diminish the literary complexity of the episode.

The folk song positions the reader as a participant in collective feeling. But which group sings here? The prologue has the stage-manager, a later scene the boatmen's community, and the subsequent narration the words of villagers. These three voices have different social origins. Folk song is a form of memory distinct from classical archives, but the absence of explicit distinctions of class, gender, or caste within a community cannot automatically be equated with equality.

Narrative Time, Duration of Presentation, and Focalisation

The temporal movement changes from the first act's present disrupted by fire, to the protracted moments of crisis in the second, the morning institutional assembly in the third, the evening conversation of grief in the fourth, and the summary of many years in the epilogue. The moment of entrapment in the water is slowed by stage directions, pauses, and cries; the existence of the memorial chamber across many years is compressed into a paragraph. The contrast between scene and summary generates the narrative's emotional rhythm.

In the enacted acts the audience chiefly receives knowledge through exterior action, voiced dialogue, and stage directions, not through an uninterrupted omniscient account of one character's inner life. The stage-manager establishes leaps in time, the background of Udayana's book, and the future connection with Channa Gachhi. External theatrical focalisation is thus joined to the stage-manager's broad temporal knowledge. It is not always appropriate to accord the same reliability to what is seen onstage and to what the stage-manager confidently says about the future.

The epilogue's "patience of twelve hundred years" signals a non-natural narrative: Budhuā's age breaks the rules governing an ordinary historical human lifespan. The story makes this extended life a figure for a vow and for folk memory; it is not metaphysical evidence concerning biological longevity. Within the reader's possible world, memory can travel across historical generations in the form of a character. Whether this rule is

applied coherently to new characters and timelines must, however, be examined in later chapters.

Trauma, Grief, and the Ethics of Representation

When Jīvantī disappears in the pond, the text does not indulge in excessive descriptions of bodily violence. Water movement, breathlessness, a broken utterance, and Budhuā's cry constitute the experience. Such restraint is appropriate to karuṇa-rasa, because attention falls upon silent loss rather than a spectacle of violence. Yet the reader's ethical task is not to forget structural accountability once grief has been expressed.

One can discern distinct movements of pathos, fear, wonder, and tranquillity in the terms of Indian poetics. The pond's depth is an excitant of fear; Jīvantī's predicament and Budhuā's helplessness centre the pathetic sentiment; the later folk belief in invisible rescue adds a dimension of wonder; and Udayana's reflections upon knowledge and memory move towards quiet contemplation. The chapter is therefore not a sustained enactment of one rasa but a sequence of changing aesthetic dispositions.

A question of aucitya nonetheless remains: in Act III, immediately after a recent death, the classical debate about the auspicious opening is quickly restored to the centre. This has a compositional and intellectual advantage, because an idea is tested against a concrete ethical event. Yet comparatively little space is given to the grief of Jīvantī's family, the other women studying with her, and the future she has lost. Criticism should acknowledge this absence while recognising the strength of the thematic argument.

Kiraṇāvalī and the Udayana–Jagannātha Narrative: Limits of Historical Claims

The original text identifies Udayanācārya as the author of Kiraṇāvalī and discusses a folk account concerning the absence of an auspicious invocation in that work. The historical allusion within the fiction, the modern invented dialogue, and the authenticated editorial text of the original Sanskrit treatise constitute separate layers. On the evidence of these passages alone, it would be incautious to announce a historical finding about the presence or absence of an invocation in every edition of Kiraṇāvalī, the chronology of its composition, or Udayanācārya's private decisions. This critique accepts the explicitly identified folk account for its literary function.

After the play concludes, a story of Udayanācārya's vision of Jagannātha in child form brings reason and devotion into contact. The embedded tale belongs more to the sphere of religious folk imagination than to established historical events. In the main drama, Udayana revises his

criterion of success; in the folk narrative, the limits of reasoning become a question of experience. A philosophical resemblance between the two is possible, but the common use of Udayana's name does not justify conclusions about actual biography.

When classical Indian theory and modern narrative ethics are brought together, the Navya-Nyāya term pramāṇa should not be treated as an ordinary synonym for "social justice." Udayana's question, "At whose cost is something completed without obstruction?", is an ethical transformation, not a literal commentary upon an original Sanskrit Nyāya aphorism. The literary value lies in this new imaginative use, not in a spurious claim of classical originality.

Event Density: Independent Events, Causal Connections, and Temporal Weight

At least eight changes of state are apparent from an examination of the scenes: preparations for the movement of manuscripts; the falling lamp-stand and the fire; the report of three bundles remaining inside; Jīvantī's plan and dangerous entry into the pond; her disappearance after her hair becomes caught in roots; the presentation of the recovered bundles in the morning; Udayana's doctrinal revision following Someśvara's question; and the rule establishing a chamber of memory. The memorial's destruction and transformation into folk tradition in the epilogue constitute two further long-term consequences. Information and event have been distinguished in this register; the count is not a definitive statistical value.

In relatively few words, the night sequence of fire, pond, and disappearance produces three high-impact turns. The density of external events is more intense here than in the earlier philosophical acts, while decisions that transform knowledge are concentrated in the morning and evening. Udayana's initial doctrine of "unobstructed" completion is revised under the pressure of an irreversible outcome: this is the cognitive consequence of the event.

The causal chain contains decisive gaps. Why did the bundles that survived the fire not perish in the water? Why was Jīvantī unable to save herself? What was the relation, if any, between a possible crocodile and her hair becoming caught in roots? Were the monastery's safety rules improved, or was only a memorial record established? Filling these gaps without evidence would be reinvention, not criticism.

Scene-by-Scene Table: Event, Evidence, Cause, and Conclusion

Scene and time	Event of the scene	Attested transformation	Unresolved claim or limit
Prologue: night	Introduction of Budhuā, Jīvantī, and the preservation of treatises	A pledge travels across generations and institutions	The Vācaspati-Udayana connection is an invented narrative bridge
Act I	A lamp falls and starts a fire; three bundles remain	Time for study becomes emergency time	Alternative protections against the fire are unclear
Act I	Jīvantī decides to put the bundles in the pond	The agency and risk of service labour come into view	Equipment, helpers, and safety assessment absent
Act II	Her hair catches in roots; her voice fails; Jīvantī disappears	Jīvantī vanishes; Budhuā's attempted rescue fails	An actual crocodile attack is unproven
Act III	At dawn the bundles survive; Someśvara questions the auspicious beginning	Udayana revises his claim of an unobstructed beginning	The physical survival of the manuscript is only partially explained
Act III	Udayana orders the rescuer's name written at the gate	A proposed change in documentary recognition	Practical safety policy unspecified
Act IV	Budhuā and Udayana speak about an unfinished sentence and the memory chamber	Generational grief becomes a communal record	Jīvantī's final intention remains uncertain
Epilogue	The memory chamber is destroyed; "Water-Maiden" becomes a folk name	Institutional destruction and a new form of oral remembrance	Historical fact remains separate from oral tradition
After the drama	Traditions about the invocation in Kiraṇāvalī and Jagannātha's vision	Interpretative dimension of philosophical intertext	Not a stage event; external history unverified

Supportive and Opposing Assessments: Literary Achievement and Limitation

The chapter's major achievement is that it turns a symbol into an event. The first four chapters explored abstract questions of evidence through philosophical debate; here the competing values of manuscript, water, and human life collide in a concrete accident. Someśvara questions his teacher, who acknowledges the limits of an earlier knowledge-claim; a transformation of thought arises from a visible calamity. The author does not depict Jīvantī merely as a helpless casualty: she possesses her own plan and courage.

The principal limitation concerns the imbalance between this independent agency and the institution's ethics of labour. In place of the flood invoked by the folk song there is an actual risk of fire; the title "The Waterlogged Manuscript" may conflict with the stated fact that the bundle is kept above the water; alternatives to the hazardous rescue plan are not developed; and, despite the creation of a memorial to her name,

the question of a living woman's rights receives insufficient treatment. The possible crocodile danger is particularly effective, but its actual participation in the event remains unresolved. All these limitations arise at points of instability in the original text.

Simply declaring the composition wholly successful or wholly unsuccessful would be inadequate. Its strengths reside in the folk resonance of the saying, the intergenerational burden of Budhuā's vow, the morning exchange between pupil and teacher, and the ethical proposal of institutional remembrance. The clarity of a didactic drama makes some characters one-dimensional, while the epilogue compresses an enormous span of time into a paragraph. This device opens out the scale of an epic saga, but limits the dramatic credibility of events developed through sustained experience.

The Chapter's Lasting Function in the Trilogy and the Next Question

"The Waterlogged Manuscript" builds a bridge from the trilogy's opening philosophical disputations towards social and environmental narrative. Budhuā's individual memory now becomes the shared property of an institutional archive, an imagined conversation across the philosophical traditions of Magadha and Mithila, and village mythology. Jīvantī's personal name changes within oral tradition, making the campaign to protect memory more complex than an uncomplicated success story.

As the narrative turns towards Chapter –94, "The Silence of Four Mouths," one important question emerges: once the chamber of memory has been destroyed, how are four different kinds of evidence—a book, a person, a folk song, and a mark left by water—to be tested against one another? No answer is conjectured here; it must be investigated through evidence in the next original text. The most appropriate conclusion of the present chapter is that writing down a name begins the work of justice, while human safety, accountability for decisions, and uncertainty about the truth must be examined alongside it.

Chapter –95: Index of Evidence Directly Checked against the Original

The following excerpts were collated with Chapter [–95] of the combined original manuscript. References by act, speaker, and epilogue are reliable; the collective printed page range 100–110 comes from the original contents and is not an independently verified individual page reference.

Opening saying: "A flood can submerge a book, but not the human voice."

Prologue, stage-manager: "With Budhuā there is also a pupil of his, Jīvantī."

Song, stage-manager: "The book grew wet, yet the song remained dry."

Act I, Someśvara: “There is no auspicious invocation at its beginning.”

Act I, Udayana: “Care, study, clear writing, and timely revision.”

Act I, pupil: “The lamp-stand has fallen.”

Act I, Jīvantī: “Three, Master! The oldest copy.”

Act I, Jīvantī: “Let us submerge it in the pond.”

Act I, Budhuā: “An old crocodile lives there.”

Act I, Jīvantī: “I know how to swim.”

Act II, Jīvantī: “The bundle is above the water, not submerged.”

Act II, Jīvantī: “My hair … it is caught in some roots.”

Act II, Budhuā: “Let go of the bundle; think of yourself!”

Act II, Jīvantī: “To bear witness for books is also …”

Act II, stage direction: “The bundle is in his hand, but Jīvantī is not there.”

Act III, Śambhunātha: “The manuscript survived.”

Act III, Udayana: “Did you first count the books, or think of Jīvantī?”

Act III, Someśvara: “A life has been sacrificed in this.”

Act III, Udayana: “My words last night were not false, but they were incomplete.”

Act III, Udayana: “The treatise itself remains indebted to that cost.”

Act III, Budhuā: “Protecting a truth already made public is a different task.”

Act IV, Budhuā: “Hulāsā’s name, and now Jīvantī’s name.”

Act IV, Udayana: “Just like Hulāsā’s palm leaf.”

Act IV, Budhuā: “This incompleteness is itself a form of evidence.”

Act IV, Udayana: “The register of treatises and the register of memory will proceed together.”

Epilogue, stage-manager: “The monastery itself fell into ruin.”

Epilogue, stage-manager: “Water-maiden.”

Epilogue, stage-manager: “Channa Gachhi.”

Post-dramatic folk account: “The folk account of the absence of an auspicious invocation in Kiraṇāvalī.”

Post-dramatic folk account: “The folk tradition of Udayanācārya and Jagannātha.”

Critical Section 7 | Original Chapter −94 — The Silence of Four Mouths

The Chapter's Decisive Question: What Is Silence Amid Speaking Philosophies?

The first paradox in the title "The Silence of Four Mouths" is that all four mouths speak incessantly. The Sāṃkhya teacher Viśvambhara, the Cārvāka poet Rudradatta, the Buddhist monk Śīlabhadra, and the Mīmāṃsaka Harinātha each expound their own arguments. Silence is not the absence of words, but the failure to act together at the appropriate moment when confronted with a crisis. The opening formula, "All four mouths spoke, yet one thing remained concealed," makes this contradiction the chapter's subject. The question before the reader is not which of the four philosophies contains the ultimate truth; it is how the presence of a hungry person exposes the incompleteness of their supposedly comprehensive knowledge.

At least three meanings of "silence" operate in the title: the neglected voices of the hungry outside the gate; the ethical speechlessness that brings argument to a halt at Sohan's death; and the obligation to remember, acknowledged when the four scholars touch the tree with their hands in the fourth act. The first silence is violent neglect, the second a shock to conscience, and the third an institutional undertaking. These changes of meaning should not be mistaken for the mechanical repetition of a word: they are the axis of narrative transformation. The epilogue's tradition that voices can be heard within the bark of the peepal tree turns silence into a potential folk archive, without establishing that a supernatural occurrence has actually taken place.

Relation to the Previous Chapter: From the Memory Chamber to the Gate

In Chapter −95, "The Waterlogged Manuscript," Jīvantī's name, the vulnerability of written records, and Budhuā's pledge to preserve memory stood at the centre of the story. The new chapter begins at the same monastery of Udayanācārya, where the aged Budhuā still carries his conch and rope. Chapter −94 does not discard the events preceding it; rather, it alters the scope of the work of remembrance. The former question was how to inscribe the name of someone humiliated or lost in water. Now the immediate protection of a living, starving person becomes the test of remembrance. Erecting a memorial and saving a life are not the same act.

In the original stage introduction Udayana is described as "now extremely old," and Budhuā is likewise "very old." Having said that the Kiraṇāvalī has spread across Mithila, the stage-manager brings the audience into a year of famine. The number of years since the preceding events is not specified, but the ageing of bodies and the circulation of a book are compressed signs of historical time. This compression of long duration contrasts sharply with the moment-by-moment ethical time of the next four acts. The difference between summary and scene is a significant device of narrative organisation.

Stage, Place, and Two Assemblies: The Politics of the Gate

The monastery courtyard lies beneath the shade of a great peepal tree. Four scholars, Udayana, and Budhuā are on one side; a crowd afflicted by famine is outside the gate. This spatial division is not merely a convenient stage direction. The monastery becomes the institutional domain of knowledge, the gate a boundary of the right to enter, the granary a site of control over resources, and the peepal a possible location of public memory. The stage-manager's statement, "Hunger makes them speak, not scripture," makes clear the unequal positions of the two assemblies: one consists of selected speakers; the other of people brought together by hunger.

Initially, those beyond the gate exist as a collective clamour. Their individual names, families, castes, and occupations are not provided. Such anonymity conveys the breadth of the crisis, but also risks making the afflicted community into scenery. Sohan enters the inner assembly as a named representative, although he barely possesses the strength to speak. Realist criticism must observe that the distressed people have been allotted less speech than the philosophers. Calling this simply a pathetic scene would leave the problem of representation unexamined.

Map of Events: Five Transitions and an Unfulfilled Possibility

Narrative state	Textual evidence	Decision or transformation	Outstanding question
Prologue	Famine; a crowd at the gate	Two assemblies remain separate	What are the rules of the granary?
Act I	A pupil reports hunger	Udayana delays; Budhuā objects	Why was no immediate order issued?
Act II	The topic of disputation changes	Four answers, but no grain distributed	Who holds the authority to decide?
Act III	Sohan collapses; his body lies lifeless	A belated order to distribute grain	Where is the causal investigation of the crisis?
Act IV	Cremation and grain distribution	The four hands touch in witness	Where is the voice of Sohan's family?
Epilogue	Rule for checking the gate; folk designation	The folklore of "Brahmā of the Peepal" emerges	No independent confirmation that the rule was followed

The prologue establishes famine, a dried-up river, cracked fields, and the custom of holding assemblies. In the first act, while the four positions are being articulated, a disciple announces that more than thirty people are waiting and that some children have not eaten for three days. Udayana says he will attend to them as soon as the debate ends; Budhuā points out the discrepancy between the time of debate and the time of hunger. In the second act Udayana changes the subject, demanding specific answers from the philosophers about the crowd at the gate. Differences of doctrine turn towards decisions about action, but no order to distribute grain is yet given. Sohan enters and staggers. In the third act he falls at the roots of the peepal; the narrative describes his body as "lifeless." Only then does Udayana order the granary opened. The fourth act shows grain being distributed after the cremation. The four scholars touch the tree and accept its future significance as a witness to memory.

The event sequence is not reducible to the death. Postponement of a decision; failure to respond despite receiving information about an emergency; changing the rules of debate without acting; giving the order only after the death; and establishing a convention of checking the gate before subsequent assemblies are distinct changes of state. The five main transitions are linked through a close ethical chain of cause and effect, although calculating a numerical event rate would require separate event coding.

Temporal Order: Philosophical Time and the Intolerable Waiting of Hunger

The chapter's most powerful temporal construction is the clash over the word "first." Udayana wants the debate completed first; Budhuā wants hunger addressed first; each philosopher wants certain principles established before action. Rudradatta considers present and perceptible hunger sufficient grounds for an immediate decision. Into these competing priorities Sohan brings the time limit of his own body. The play's ethical tension lies not in the ultimate defeat of an argument but in the irreversible consequences of postponing action while thinking proceeds.

The first two acts unfold through extensive exposition. Death in the third occurs within a few brief stage directions and lines of dialogue. The silence of the body that will not rise bears more narrative weight than prolonged instruction. At the beginning of the fourth act the audience learns that Sohan's cremation has already occurred: the time between death and funeral has been omitted. The epilogue compresses the return of rain, green fields, later debates, and the growth of a folk name into a summary spanning years. Unequal durations put pressure on the reader, while the

exact interval during which relief might have arrived before Sohan's death remains unspecified.

Four Philosophies: Independent Voices and Narrative Bias

Viśvambhara employs the language of prakṛti, the three guṇas, and discrimination in discussing the end of suffering; immediate grain distribution is not, in his account, the fundamental cure for suffering. This raises a distinction between long-term and immediate remedies, but the alleged transience of relief does not make it necessarily worthless. The play depicts one particularly severe application of his position. It would be unreasonable to infer from it a final judgement on the practical ethics of the entire Sāṃkhya tradition. Such a qualification preserves the distinction between the ideas of a literary character and the doctrine of a historical school.

Rudradatta openly demands that the hungry be fed: "Give them food, that is all." It therefore contradicts the text to say that all four characters are equally indifferent. His verbal demand is explicit, although he does not himself open the granary or organise the crowd onstage. The ethical directness of his argument and the absence of practical action coexist. Criticism must retain the distinction. If control of the stores belongs to Udayana and his disciples, Rudradatta's responsibility for inaction may be correspondingly more limited; the text does not spell out the distribution of authority.

Śīlabhadra speaks for compassion but becomes entangled in scholastic reflections on the threefold structure of giving. His characterisation contrasts compassion with the fog created by its explanation. He also expresses shame, allowing a small moment of self-correction. Yet complex ideas concerning the perfection of generosity do not represent the whole of Buddhist practice; they have been selected and compressed to achieve dramatic irony. Harinātha treats a gift as voluntary unless authorised by an injunction and argues from ownership of the granary. His speech exemplifies a rigid application of rules during a crisis; it is not identical with the entire historical tradition of Mīmāṃsā and its philosophy of duty.

Udayana's Change of Role: From Presiding over Debate to Acknowledging Fault

Udayanācārya begins as the assembly's president and the person with decision-making power at the monastery. His first decision—to wait for the debate to finish—becomes an ethical delay in the story's outcome. His change of subject in the second act is a significant intermediate alteration: he asks what all four philosophies have to say about the hungry crowd. Yet posing a question is not opening the granary. His intellectual awakening

and his practical awakening occur at different moments, and Sohan's death exposes the distance between them.

In the third act the cry "Food … distribute food now! At once!" comes too late. In the fourth Udayana acknowledges that this was not philosophy's defeat, but the defeat of people who loved philosophy more than the person before them. The self-criticism does not undo the earlier delay, but it prevents him from being a wholly one-dimensional oppressor. Even at the end, the institutional power to name the peepal the "Witness Tree" remains with him. An ethical change has taken place without entirely transforming the structure of authority. No representative of the afflicted villagers is entrusted with drafting the new rule, an omission that criticism must note.

Budhuā: From a Pledge to Preserve Memory to Public Dissent

Budhuā is not an accredited representative of classical logic in this chapter, but he is the principal voice that redirects the actual decision. His statement in the first act, "Hunger does not wait for a philosophical debate to finish," is the most concise expression of the conflict over time. He is the first to run when Sohan falls. At the death he recalls the order of the philosophers' arguments and asks, "Food first, debate afterwards." Without recourse to any formal scholastic category, his question becomes the assembly's evidentiary test.

In the fourth act Budhuā effectively becomes a maker of the ethics of remembrance. Hulāsā's name on a stone, Jīvantī's in the memory chamber, and Sohan's death marked in the bark of a peepal constitute three levels of witnessing. Moving beyond the inscription of names, he makes the place itself a prompt that demands remembrance. But Budhuā, too, does not ask Sohan's family or a member of the hungry crowd to determine the wording of the new rule. The novel seeks to establish the worth of knowledge grounded in service rather than to condemn ignorance; equality in the authority to speak for memory nevertheless remains an unfinished aim.

Sohan: Receiving a Name, Losing a Voice, and the Ethical Difficulty of Representation

Sohan is named in the cast, but his time onstage is extremely brief. He staggers while saying, "For three days … the children …," and falls at the roots of the peepal. He receives no independent portrayal of illness, family, work, caste, or life before the famine. This reduction may be a deliberate dramatic compression: one body becomes the intolerable consequence placed before the doctrines. But the form also contains the risk that a

sufferer becomes merely a means to awaken the conscience of respectable society.

The story describes a "lifeless body," so Sohan's death is an asserted fact of its fictional plot. It does not provide an independent medical investigation establishing starvation as the precise cause. The famine and his immediate collapse produce a powerful ethical implication, but the cause of death, absence of relief, and institutional responsibility require distinct examination. The event is decisive to the narrative's morality, but a fictional scene must not be cited as an actual historical record of death.

Narrator and Focalisation: Changing Authority of the Stage-Manager

In the prologue the stage-manager presents historical time, the spread of the book, the characters' old age, and the famine. Within the acts, stage directions, direct speech, movements of bodies, and sounds from the crowd become the principal sources of information. Signs such as "the four scholars are silent" or "eyes lowered" present observable conduct, not omniscient accounts of the whole interior lives of the characters. The epilogue restores the stage-manager's wider temporal view as he recounts rain, the convention that followed, and communal speech. Limited focalisation in the enacted scene thus alternates with expansive narration in summary.

The recurrence of "it is said" in the final folk account is important. The claim that four voices may be heard in the peepal's bark is not presented as a supernatural occurrence directly certified by the narrator; it is a belief reported within the story. It is therefore difficult to declare the chapter straightforwardly and definitively an instance of magical realism. More cautiously, it is a folkloric transformation of memory. Yet where the stage-manager preserves the limit of communal hearsay, the later prediction that "all four answers will prove false" speaks with more decisive moral certainty. Narrative distance changes between these two modes.

Levels of the Dramatic Narrative: Song, Stage Directions, and Subsequent Commentary

The chapter calls itself a dramatic work consisting of "a prologue, four acts, and an epilogue." Its introductory folk song anticipates the idea that all four mouths will speak while something remains silent; the subsequent action gives this premise concrete social meaning. The song foreshadows the ethical outcome, but by making the moral judgement clear even before the calamity, it may diminish the reader's uncertainty. At some points the four philosophical voices genuinely test one another; at others they become adversarial positions arranged by the author.

After the epilogue, the heading “Stories and Illustrations Associated with Sāṃkhya, Cārvāka, Buddhism, and Mīmāṃsā” introduces two explanatory notes, one on a famous Cārvāka maxim and the other on the Mīmāṃsā theory of injunctive statements. This philosophical supplementary text is not a stage event, even though it lies within the physical boundaries of the chapter. The discussion of the Cārvāka saying itself cautions that it is often cited through works written by opponents; it should not therefore be treated unquestioningly as a verbatim, authoritative statement from an original historical source. The distinction between analysis of the central drama and the author's collection of explanatory material is necessary for word counts, intertextual study, and verification of references alike.

Rasa, Dhvani, and Aucitya: The Force of Pathos and an Overly Simple Moral Resolution

The cracked earth of famine, news of starving children, Sohan's staggering arrival, and Budhuā's stillness by the dead body form the structure of karuṇa-rasa, the sentiment of pathos. Its effect arises not only from words of lamentation but from the unequal sense of urgency governing debate and immediate assistance. When the fall at the peepal's roots follows extended argument, the suggestion (dhvani) of silence is stronger than explicit speech. In the sense of Indian poetics it can be read as a social accusation whose force exceeds the everyday literal meaning of the words. This does not mean that dhvani in poetics and “focalisation” in modern narratology are interchangeable.

On the criterion of aucitya, or appropriateness, the movement in the fourth act from Sohan's death to the founding of the Witness Tree works effectively because a physical place becomes a durable sign of culpable neglect. Nevertheless, the instantaneous humility of the four scholars after the death and their ready acceptance of a new rule may seem too convenient. The text depicts no prolonged resistance, objection from the keeper of the grain, or inequalities in its distribution. The clarity of the desired ethical outcome strengthens the composition but lessens the complexity of the actual struggle. Uncritical praise of pathos would run counter to the novel's demand for justice.

A Navya-Nyāya Examination of Evidence: What Has and Has Not Been Established?

The subject (pakṣa) is the conduct of the participants in this particular monastery assembly; the property to be established (sādhya) is their ethical failure to provide immediate relief during the crisis; the reason (hetu) is the continued suspension of grain distribution after news of hunger had arrived. The disciple's report about the children is the dramatic form of

testimony; the crowd's noise, Sohan's staggering, and his collapse are directly enacted evidence. Udayana's delayed order and later self-criticism are also established through the character's actions. These support the occurrence of institutional delay within the story. They do not establish a universal proposition such as "all philosophies are helpless in the face of hunger" from the evidence of a single assembly.

The inquiry into cause and effect raises the question of delimiting conditions: who actually controlled the grain, whether disciples could distribute it independently, and whether sufficient supplies were available during famine remain unspecified. Without these facts it risks fallacious reasoning to treat the existence of all four philosophies as a sufficient cause of Sohan's death. Rudradatta, in particular, calls for immediate assistance, so the proposed reason of uniformly shared inaction is unestablished. A stronger conclusion is that the person who possessed decision-making power acted late, and the play makes the moral consequences of that delay visible. This is an application of Navya-Nyāya tools to the novel's reasoning, not a verbatim reproduction of a historical debate found in a primary treatise.

The Videha Parallel-History Perspective: Folk Archives and Institutional Forgetting

The debates at the monastery form a systematic history of metaphysical thought; hunger outside its gate might easily remain marginal in the official record. Budhuā refuses to confine this difference to a stone inscription or manuscript and makes it a discipline of communal memory. The names Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sohan become an attempt to connect three different forms of neglect and preservation of testimony. In this sense the peepal is an alternative archive. Its principal evidence is not miraculous voices but the collective convention of asking about conditions at the gate before beginning any debate.

Yet the Videha parallel-history method is not confined to adding neglected names. It also asks who possesses the authority to construct history. Udayana names the peepal the "Witness Tree," the four philosophers leave marks of touch, and Budhuā makes the proposal, but no collective signatures of the hungry are shown. The absence of Sohan's family's account must remain on the critical record. The teacher's transformation matters; a history owned by its sufferers remains a question, not a completed achievement.

Environmental Narrative: The Dry River, Grain Store, and Body of the Tree

Famine is more than scenic decoration. The dried river and cracked fields establish the conditions of scarcity, while people gathering at the monastery gate raise the question of distributing the grain kept within. Nature and institution are directly related: the lack of water intensifies social hardship, but the grain held in storage makes relief possible. Thus a failure of human decision-making cannot be dismissed as nothing more than natural disaster. For understanding the trilogy built around Channa Gachhi, ponds, rivers, and sites of memory, this inverted form of the water crisis—water's absence—is particularly significant.

The peepal supplies shade at the beginning, receives Sohan's fallen body at its roots in the third act, becomes the site of witnessing by touch in the fourth, and carries a folk name in the epilogue. One natural object thus performs four narrative functions. The rain and green fields at the end nevertheless signify the passing of famine without depicting concrete reforms to food distribution, seed preservation, or water management. If natural recovery is equated with social justice, the novel's environmental question remains only half answered.

Construction of the Metaphor: From Witness Tree to "Brahmā of the Peepal"

The placing of the four scholars' hands upon the bark in Act IV is an ordinary, visible action. Udayana subsequently declares the tree's public name. In the epilogue villagers gradually begin calling it "Brahmā of the Peepal," associating four mouths with the four schools of philosophy. Visible action, institutional naming, and communal tradition form three successive stages of meaning. Four mouths may evoke the traditional many-faced iconography of Brahmā, but no actual divine incarnation is established within the drama.

Through this transformation the tree becomes a natural archive: its roots witnessed a death, its bark received the sign of touch, and its name became a warning to future generations. The opening song declares that silence remains behind all answers; at the end the tree seems to bear many voices. The primary warning, however, is that no one's hunger should be disregarded. The symbol succeeds ethically if that meaning actually changes conduct. The play provides no practical verification beyond the epilogue's statement that it does.

Polyphony and Its Limits: How Autonomous Are the Opposing Voices?

Each philosopher has a different mode of speech: the conceptual scheme of Sāṃkhya, the sensory immediacy and sarcasm of Cārvāka, Buddhist compassion and the perplexities of emptiness, and Mīmāṃsā's authority of injunction. These differences make the play polyphonic to a degree, but its plurality of voices is not entirely autonomous. Udayana and Budhuā retain the authority to establish the ethical conclusion, and all four opponents arrive at broadly similar repentance. Rudradatta's earlier demand for immediate relief particularly complicates this uniform ending. It is unjust to assign him exactly the culpability of Harinātha, whose appeal to rules obstructed assistance.

Sociologically, the villagers remain a collective sound rather than participants in an independent deliberation. The figure "more than thirty" lends an almost administrative specificity, but the naming stops at Sohan. The story attacks the authority of elite knowledge, yet its own narrative structure gives learned men more opportunities to speak. Calling this simply a failure would flatten the difficulty. It is better to register the contradiction and ask whether the people acquire more expansive voices later in the trilogy.

Achievements, Limitations, and a Revisable Conclusion for the Trilogy

The chapter's chief achievement is to connect complex philosophical disputation to a concrete public decision. The site of debate, the crowd at the gate, Sohan's diminished speech, Udayana's delayed order, Budhuā's dissent, and the touch of the peepal are organised into one dramatic line. Previously, preservation of a name had centred upon individual memory; now it aspires to become a rule of collective ethical conduct. The silence in the title acquires not only an emotional meaning but a political one: the failure to act in time.

The limitations are equally concrete. Rudradatta is placed among the equally guilt-ridden despite his express defence of immediate assistance; the Sāṃkhya, Buddhist, and Mīmāṃsā positions are sometimes oversimplified; Sohan's death functions more as a catalyst for philosophical instruction than as the conclusion of an independent life; the hungry crowd's voice is compressed into collective noise; and reform is largely represented by immediate assent and popular naming. No institutional account of Sohan's death or grain distribution is presented; the return of rain does not prove that the structural causes of starvation have disappeared. These questions arise from a serious testing of the chapter's ethical claim, not from a dismissal of its achievements.

The peepal becomes first a source of shade, then the site of death, then the place of a name. The moral order of "first" changes; the voices of the four mouths end not in victory but in self-examination. The epilogue anticipates that all four answers will prove false in the future Channa Gachhi narrative. That prediction must be tested against subsequent chapters, not treated as an event already fulfilled. With this qualification, "The Silence of Four Mouths" becomes an important early junction between knowledge, hunger, evidence, and public memory within the trilogy.

Chapter −94: Index of Evidence Collated with the Original Text

Prologue, stage-manager: "Hunger makes them speak, not scripture."

Prologue, folk song: "Those who gave all the answers still had one question left."

Act I, disciple: "More than thirty people have gathered."

Act I, Udayanācārya: "I shall come as soon as the debate ends."

Act I, Budhuā: "Hunger does not wait for a philosophical debate to finish."

Act II, Udayanācārya: "I am changing the subject of today's debate."

Act II, Rudradatta: "Give them food, that is all."

Act II, Harinātha: "The monastery's grain belongs to the monastery, not the village."

Act II, Śīlabhadra: "I … I said it only for the sake of scholastic clarity."

Act II, Sohan: "Master … for three days … the children …"

Act III, stage direction: "Sohan falls at the roots of the peepal."

Act III, Udayanācārya: "Food … distribute food now! At once!"

Act III, stage direction: "Sohan's lifeless body."

Act III, Budhuā: "Food first, debate afterwards."

Act III, Udayanācārya: "This is not philosophy's defeat; it is our … defeat."

Act IV, stage direction: "Sohan's cremation has taken place."

Act IV, Budhuā: "Make this tree a witness to Sohan."

Act IV, Udayanācārya: "From today this tree shall be called the monastery's Witness Tree."

Epilogue, stage-manager: "First ask about conditions at the gate, then begin the debate."

Epilogue, stage-manager: “Brahmā of the Peepal.”

Epilogue, stage-manager: “Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sohan.”

Epilogue, stage-manager: “All four answers will prove false.”

Post-dramatic note: “The famous maxim of the Cārvākas.”

Post-dramatic note: “The Mīmāṃsā theory of injunctive statements.”

Critical Section 8 | Original Chapter −93 — The Conch's Final Question

Chapter −93, “The Conch's Final Question,” is the eighth chapter of Part Zero. In the contents of the original combined novel its opening is given as page 120, while the following Chapter −92, “The Prisoner of the Water Clock,” begins on page 131. Accordingly, pages 120–130 are the printed-page range attributable to the chapter. This is a range inferred from the contents, however, and not independently checked page by page against a printed copy. It would be wrong to treat the proportion of text to pages as an actual count of events: a single disputational dialogue may raise several questions, while how far a character's position changes remains a separate issue. The opening saying, “Even what you have once recognised asks you again at dawn,” establishes a repeated tension between recognition and doubt. The specific research question posed by the original entry is how the proposition, opposition, and verdict of a philosophical debate are transformed into narrative, and whether argument enters a character's lived actions or remains mere exposition. The present criticism examines that question against narrative consequences, the epistemology of Navya-Nyāya, and the ethical demands of compassion.

From “The Conch and Silver” to “The Final Question”: The Narrative Commitment of Return

The initial conch-and-silver dispute in Chapter −100 returns here as the remembered past of the fictional world. Both the stage-manager and Budhuā state that the Objector's doubt goes back sixty years. Thus an illustration introduced once does not remain an isolated subject. It returns across an interval of seven chapters having absorbed experiences of death, social failure, and the inscription of names. This connection between the order of events and their presentation matters. The enacted scene takes place in the evening in a quiet courtyard behind Udayanācārya's monastery; within it, however, the narrator gathers the first debating hall of Vācaspati, the deaths of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sohan, and the village's future memory. This is not mere repetition. The value of the question has changed: what began as a problem in knowledge has become a question about the worth of one person's sixty years of lived experience. Nevertheless, “sixty years” is a temporal claim internal to the story, not independently verified historical chronology.

Theatre within the Composition: Prologue, Four Acts, and Epilogue

The chapter describes itself as “an original dramatic work divided into a prologue, four acts, and an epilogue.” Its list of characters includes the

stage-manager, Udayanācārya, Budhuā, the Objector, the disciple Keśava, and the council. The council's purported "whispering," however, does not develop into substantive independent dialogue: the real exchange is concentrated in the triangle formed by Udayana, the Objector, and Budhuā. The prologue restores the memory of the old debate; Act I brings the Objector physically into the scene and raises the question of death; Act II extends the crisis of the knower through a discussion of three accounts of erroneous cognition; Act III introduces Budhuā's ethical answer and reinterprets doubt as an existential condition; Act IV changes the rules of the represented world through death and a silver-like radiance; and the epilogue both closes and reopens the story through communal belief, funeral rites, and anticipations of later events. Stage directions and the stage-manager's external narration operate on different levels. Speech within the play belongs to particular people, while the epilogue's formula "it is said" marks knowledge transmitted by hearsay within the community.

Event Map: From the Arrival of a Question to Posthumous Folk Memory

Sequence on stage	Direct evidence	Change of state	Critical limitation
Prologue	Vācaspati's assembly; return of the Objector	Sixty years of uncertainty made public	Events during the intervening years are not developed
Act I	Keśava brings in the elderly man; Budhuā recognises him	A guest becomes an old philosophical opponent	Travel details rest on recollection
Act II	Three theories of error; the question of the knower	A doctrinal answer becomes a personal crisis	Doctrinal disagreement does not prove the absence of truth
Act III	Budhuā names three deceased persons	A turn from epistemic proof toward an ethics of witnessing	The causes of the three social tragedies differ
Act IV	Silver-like radiance after the Objector's death	The last question remains unanswered; a marvel is witnessed	The metaphysical cause of the radiance is unknown
Epilogue	Cremation; the name "Rākash"; folklore surrounding the tree	A personal question enters communal memory	Folklore does not independently corroborate fact

The demonstrable changes of state can be arranged in five stages. First, Keśava brings a helpless elderly visitor to the monastery; Budhuā identifies him by his voice, and a stranger becomes an old acquaintance. Second, the Objector redirects the competition of ideas towards his own fear of death; the purpose of the debate changes. Third, Udayana proposes a limited common ground between rival positions, but the Objector rejects this resolution by asking about the knower. Fourth, Budhuā sets aside the standard scholastic response and speaks of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sohan, and the moral meaning of his decision to bear witness. The Objector dies before he

can finish his final utterance. Fifth, the strange silver-like light and its movement towards the tree become the folk belief named "Rākash" in the epilogue. External action is restricted, while knowledge, emotion, and communal remembrance undergo substantial transformations. It is consistent with the novel's critical discipline not to impose a conclusive explanation where none is given. To call the Objector's death immediate proof of self-realisation would be an overreading.

Time: The Compression of Sixty Years and the Extended Hours of an Evening

Using Gérard Genette's concepts of narrative time, sixty years of story-time are presented through brief recollection, while a few hours of scenic time expand into prolonged dialogue. The stage-manager begins with a summary of the distant past; Budhuā later becomes a witness to that memory; the epilogue leaps forward to the funeral and to a tradition said to endure for years. The changing light, from a saffron evening sky to deep moonlight, also measures time within the scene. The formal four acts divide the evening, but the Objector's weakening breath conveys its irreversible movement. The story gives neither the exact day or year of his death nor a historically precise date linking Vācaspati's assembly to Udayana's monastery. A definitive external chronology therefore cannot be derived from the memory of sixty years. The compression succeeds in revealing the generational life of a philosophical dispute, although the intervening journey is sustained largely by retrospective statements rather than enacted experience.

"Who Speaks?" and "Who Sees?": Stratification of the Narrator

At the beginning, the stage-manager directly addresses the audience —"You will remember"—and recalls the preceding chapters. This is the external organising voice, not the private experience of one of the dramatic characters. In the central courtyard scene the dialogue belongs to the characters, while the stage directions register observable conditions without claiming exhaustive access to anyone's mind. Keśava does not know the Objector's identity; Budhuā recognises his voice; Udayana knows the name and its circumstances from the tradition handed down by his teacher. Through these three modes of knowing, the composition presents the difference between immediate perception, memory, and inherited verbal testimony without affixing abstract theoretical labels to every event. At the end Keśava is frightened by the radiance, Udayana acknowledges "I do not know," and Budhuā interprets it as a memorial to doubt. The three responses to the same extraordinary sight prevent the reader from depending on a single omniscient explanation.

The Objector: The Right to Question Rather Than a Fixed Doctrine

After an interval of seven chapters, the Objector returns not simply as an old participant in philosophical controversy but as a person troubled by the cost of his questioning. Declaring, "This question is not for the debate; it is for me myself," he turns away from the public reward of victory towards a private crisis of life. In Act II he does not declare methods of knowledge worthless. He says he agrees with the theory of anyathākhyāti, yet still faces the separate questions of whether his entire life has been an illusion and what the knower's reality might be. Thus the opposing character is not reduced to a thoughtless atheist or an obstacle. Nevertheless, after he says, "I … am seeing something clearly," his final sentence breaks off. The composition deliberately withholds the last answer even as the silver radiance tempts the reader to believe that an answer has arrived. The character's dignity lies in his continuing right to question, not in surrender to a particular school.

Udayanācārya: Dialogue between Positions and the Acceptance of Ignorance

In explaining anyathākhyāti, Udayana emphasises the actual difference between the conch and silver and their erroneous conjunction in cognition. When the Objector supplies other explanations, Udayana says that disagreement between schools does not necessarily deny the actual occurrence of illusory experience; they differ over its inner mechanism. This searches for a minimum of agreement in the structure of dispute, not a final settlement of ontology. When Budhuā seeks to answer, Udayana restrains his own teaching authority and gives him permission to speak—a concrete redistribution of speech onstage. The last test of this act comes in Act IV: when the disciple asks about the light, Udayana replies, "I do not know, Keśava." Admitting the boundary of knowledge is here an ethical achievement. Any subsequent explanation qualified by "perhaps," however, remains inference, not verified evidence of the event's cause.

Budhuā: From a Servant's Voice to the Ethical Authority of a Witness

Budhuā does not treat his experience of service as a merely deferential tradition. Having witnessed Sohan's death from hunger in Chapter –94, he now speaks the names "Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sohan" and argues that the formal instruments of proof repeatedly arrived too late, whereas the decision to bear witness could not always be postponed. This is the decisive narrative turn. In Act III Budhuā asks the teacher's permission to speak. Social hierarchy remains intact at the level of form, but the ethical centre of the subject shifts from the head of the monastery to the servant. He does not say that knowledge is useless; he calls attention to the practical limits of knowledge. His insistence upon memory and love is not a philosophical

demonstration of the self but a demand for responsibility grounded in experience. There is a critical limitation as well: the three dead persons are present in Budhuā's recollection, but none speaks in this scene. Naming victims and giving them independent rights of representation are not the same thing.

Theories of Error and Their Test under Navya-Nyāya

The play presents anyathākhyāti, akhyāti, and anirvacanīyakhyāti as three distinct classical accounts. It would be inappropriate to collapse the Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika account of the perceived conch, the recollection of silver seen elsewhere, and their erroneous attribution into the Prābhākara doctrine of failing to apprehend a distinction. Advaita's anirvacanīyakhyāti likewise makes a specific proposal concerning the real-or-unreal status of cognition, not a vague assertion that "both are true" or "both are false." The speakers and the post-dramatic explanation provide abbreviated literary forms of these teachings, not substitutes for a complete history of their textual traditions. The Objector's inference—different schools disagree, therefore truth is impossible to establish—would have as its subject the ontological nature of illusion, as its reason the diversity of interpretations, and as its property to be proved the impossibility of determination. Its required pervasion, "where there is disagreement, evidence fails," is not established. Disagreement does not entail the falsity of every proof. Udayana identifies the limit of this defective inference; he does not thereby establish the existence of the knower or resolve life and death.

The Transformation of the Question: Epistemic Proof and Practical Choice

The Objector asks directly: if his entire life has been an illusion, "who was the knower of that illusion?" Budhuā locates his answer not within the dispute over proofs but in the human decision to become a witness. The Objector immediately counters, "But that is not an answer to the question of knowledge," and Budhuā explicitly concedes the point. This concession must not be overlooked. The composition does not resolve the metaphysical problem of epistemology here; rather, it distinguishes that problem from the sphere of ethical conduct. Knowing the truth of an object through perception or inference and deciding to protect someone's memory are different kinds of claims. When "evidence falls silent," it does not follow that whatever contradicts the evidence must be true. What becomes clear is only that practical duties cannot invariably wait for complete philosophical certainty. This fine distinction is the chapter's most successful development of ideas.

Symbols: The Conch's Own Worth and the Lure of Silver

The familiar conch-and-silver illustration becomes a metaphor for existence rather than remaining a standard example of erroneous sight. Budhuā tells the Objector that the conch has worth even when it is not silver, because it is a conch and someone holds it. The worth of existence enters in place of the mere correctness of identifying an object. Remarkably, after the death a silver-like radiance emerges near the Objector's eyes. Silver, initially the symbol of mistaken identity, now seems to become the shining of a question. The attractiveness of the transformation also creates a critical tension: if the moral demand is to see the conch as a conch, why does the text finally lead the reader towards a seemingly miraculous answer in the form of silver light? This may be deliberate intertextual irony, but the source provides no single definitive resolution. Treating the radiance as direct proof of a self or a philosophical truth would go beyond the text.

Death, Unnatural Narrative, and the Rules of Possible Worlds

The Objector's breath fails in Act IV, and the stage directions present his death. Immediately afterwards a small silver-like light rises into the air and moves towards the peepal. Within realist stage conventions this is extraordinary. If the story accepts such an event as part of its magical-social world's rules, it can be read as unnatural narrative. Yet the composition does not turn the event into unanimous knowledge among the characters: Keśava asks a question, Udayana admits his bewilderment and ignorance, and Budhuā offers a commemorative interpretation. A distance remains between "what was seen" and "what it means." Unless these levels are separated, an unusual image will be mistaken for proof of a metaphysical entity. The villagers' later naming of it "Rākash" is a communal act of naming, not a scientifically established classification of something supernatural. The phonetic or cultural etymology of that name is not independently established by the scene.

The Peepal as Witness Tree: The Social Transformation of Place

Following Sohan's death in Chapter –94, the peepal was proposed as the Witness Tree. Here its shade becomes a place associated with the Objector's funeral, while the tradition of the light gathers around it. Repetition turns the tree from a fixed emblem into a spatial archive of memory. Events in the monastery courtyard enter communal recollection through its roots. An active environmental disaster involving river, pond, or water is not central to this scene; names associated with the previous water calamity survive within the tradition of remembrance. From the perspective of environmental narratology, the peepal is not a direct agent making human decisions, but it is a durable physical location through which

evidence may be carried across generations. Its literary power lies in that social persistence: the tree does not itself pronounce a philosophical verdict.

The Ethics of Narration: Victims' Names and the Silence of the Dead

Budhuā's invocation of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sohan brings three distinct earlier tragedies into the dramatic present. Hulāsā's incomplete writing, Jīvantī's disappearance in water, and Sohan's hunger belong to different narrative situations. Gathering them under one philosophical concern creates a link through memory, but it may also displace investigation of the particular social or administrative causes of each death. Sohan's death had specifically been linked to the failure to distribute food in time; here it risks being absorbed into the general metaphor of "evidence arriving late." To preserve the dignity of the victims, criticism must retain the distinctions: not every death is an identical example of evidentiary failure. Because the Objector's last sentence breaks off, the dead man has no completed reply. The author's refusal to supply one may itself be a sign of ethical restraint.

Song, Dhvani, and Rasa: The Rhythm of an Open Question

The epilogue's song recalls the language of the opening saying: questions do not tire, and answers need not be feared. Such recurrence strengthens the chapter's circular form. The narrative returns from the conch-and-silver opening to the conch. Karuṇa-rasa emerges in the elderly Objector's death, adbhuta-rasa in the silver-like radiance, and the possibility of tranquillity in Budhuā's words that "doubt has now come to rest." The play, however, deliberately leaves unresolved whether the Objector attained a definite answer. A complete realisation of the tranquil sentiment cannot therefore be asserted. In terms of suggestion (dhvani), the tension between a "fixed answer" and "asking again" is significant: questioning does not simply destroy an answer but subjects it to trial. The song's limitation is that some argumentative complexity is compressed into uncomplicated encouraging verses. Yet its function in carrying a sombre scene of death towards collective memory is creatively effective.

Intertextuality and History: Mithila's Schools and Literary Characters

The names Vācaspati Miśra and Udayanācārya, together with references to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā, and Advaita Vedānta, connect the imagined world with a long philosophical tradition. But Udayana's supposed conversation here, and Budhuā's reunion with the Objector after sixty years, cannot be treated as verified historical events. They are dialogues composed by the novelist using classical names and concepts. The post-dramatic note, "Doctrinal Differences concerning the Conch-

and-Silver Theory of Illusion," is not part of the plot but explanatory material supplied by the author. It distinguishes the approaches of Nyāya, Prābhākara thought, and Advaita. To identify it as a verbatim translation of the original Sanskrit treatises would require separate verification against textual editions. The Videha parallel-history perspective is useful here for connecting scholastic discourse to popular witness: the servant Budhuā's experience acquires value, but it cannot simply stand in place of the dead persons' own perspectives.

Distribution of Information: Unequal Knowledge among New and Returning Readers

Readers who have progressed from Chapter –100 possess the background of the Objector's name, the earlier illustration of illusion, and Budhuā's witnessing. The new scene briefly recalls that history through a few expressions. But someone reading Chapter –93 in isolation encounters the three dead persons only in compressed references, not through the complete causal histories of their deaths. This compression brings both advantages and risks to a long narrative. By saying "You will remember," the stage-manager activates readers' memory while assuming they have read the preceding chapters. The epilogue anticipates a later kabaddi game at Channa Gachhi and the radiance associated with Rākash. Such anticipation cannot be called final confirmation; it is a promise to be tested in subsequent narrative. The chapter stages not the extinction of doubt, but its transformation.

Critical Judgement: Achievements, Limitations, and the Next Narrative Turn

This chapter is notable for connecting its earlier philosophical debate with death, memory, and the ethical speech of a servant. The personalisation of the Objector's question, Budhuā's social memory, Udayana's admission of ignorance, and the relative autonomy of folk belief are its strengths. Its greatest achievement is that disagreement in argument is not taken as the destruction of argument itself: an unfinished final sentence restrains claims to certainty. Its principal limitation is that most of the burden of the sixty-year intellectual journey falls upon the stage-manager's account rather than scenes from the Objector's intervening life. The different social causes of Hulāsā's, Jīvantī's, and Sohan's losses risk excessive compression into a single moral formula; and the literary success of the silver radiance can give a deceptive impression of miraculous resolution. The word "victory" in the final song does not harmonise completely with the Objector's unanswered last utterance. It should be read critically as an irony of the open question. In the next Chapter –92 the life of the disciple Keśava and the village's judicial processes move forward. The extent to

which the ethical insight achieved here passes into institutional action will therefore receive another substantial test.

Chapter −93: Index of Evidence Directly Collated with the Original Text

Prologue, stage-manager: “Long ago, in Vācaspati Miśra's debating hall.”

Cast: “The disciple Keśava—Udayana's young student.”

Setting: “A quiet courtyard behind the monastery.”

Act I, Keśava: “He does not tell us his name.”

Act I, Budhuā: “Sixty years have passed.”

Act I, Objector: “This question is not for the debate; it is for me myself.”

Act I, Objector: “What is death? The end of illusion.”

Act II, Udayana: “Illusion is false cognition, not a false object.”

Act II, Objector: “Three schools, three answers.”

Act II, Objector: “Who was the knower of that illusion?”

Act III, Budhuā: “This is not a question of scripture but of life.”

Act III, Budhuā: “Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sohan.”

Act III, Objector: “But that is not an answer to the question of knowledge.”

Act III, Budhuā: “Perhaps the answer to your question is not in knowledge.”

Act III, Budhuā: “Only see the conch as a conch.”

Act IV, Objector: “For the first time in sixty years, I am seeing something clearly.”

Act IV, stage direction: “His breath fails.”

Act IV, stage direction: “A silver-like radiance emerges.”

Act IV, Keśava: “What is this?”

Act IV, Udayana: “I do not know, Keśava.”

Act IV, Budhuā: “Doubt has now come to rest.”

Epilogue: “Rākash.”

Epilogue: “At the kabaddi game in Channa Gachhi.”

Post-dramatic note: “Anyathākhyāti, akhyāti, and anirvacanīyakhyāti.”

Critical Section 9 | Original Chapter −92 — The Prisoner of the Water Clock

Chapter −92, "The Prisoner of the Water Clock," is the ninth original chapter of Part Zero. The contents of the combined original novel give its opening as page 131 and the beginning of the next chapter, −91, "The Light of the Leatherworkers' Quarter," as page 138; its printed-page reference is therefore 131–137. This is the page span supplied by the source's contents, not an automatic page count from this combined Word document or an independent recount of a printed copy. The "high-intensity indicator" signifies only a mechanical proportion of action-related paragraphs; it cannot be treated as evidence of a definite number of events per thousand words. The following analysis joins that question to social justice, unequal access to information, and institutional control over time.

A Transformation of Narrative Form: From the Stage of Philosophical Debate to the Village Tribunal

Up to Chapter −93, cast lists, acts, and stage directions largely governed the dramatic form. The new chapter declares its form at the outset: "An excerpt from a novel; moving away from dramatic form into narrative." This is more than a decorative change. The focus shifts from definitions of philosophical principles to the everyday operation of justice, irrigation of fields, the effects of debt, and the opportunity to be heard. Addressing the audience in the first person, the narrator says, "I am going to tell you today," explicitly distinguishing the time of the events from the time of their telling. Keśava, the youthful disciple of the preceding chapter, is now Ācārya Keśava; the philosophical inheritance of his teacher is being tested within judicial procedure. Budhuā remains a witness bearing a conch, but his role moves from witnessing philosophical questions to witnessing the deprivation of social opportunity. The chapter is consequently both a continuation of the preceding philosophical debates and a practical examination of their claims.

Establishing Time and Place: "Narikel-Ghat" and the Future "Garh Narikel"

The narrator explicitly states that the village was called "Narikel-Ghat" at the time of these events; the word "Garh" will be added later in connection with the construction of an embankment to ward off flooding. This shift in names between Narikel-Ghat of the past and Garh Narikel of the present carries the reader forward towards a future time, while the immediate action remains located in the earlier village. The two portions of the paired ponds—one deep, the other shallow—and the

channel connecting them constitute a concrete arrangement of local waters. The peepal witness-tree, the line of coconut trees, and the bend in the Kamala-Balan are thoroughly physical places; they should not be dismissed as mere symbols. What appears first is not the village's official political history but the local geography of livelihood. The fisher Dhīvar, the rice cultivator Sukhdev, buffaloes, and uses of water are brought into one frame. Together they show that control over the channel is not a private quarrel between two families but a question of communal subsistence.

A Causal Map of Events: From Blocking the Channel to a Rule Made After Death

Sequence of events	Direct textual basis	Change of state	Unresolved or critical question
Establishing the location	Narikel-Ghat, Jorī pond, peepal tree	Water, fields, and communal hearings converge at one place	The later name "Garh" postdates the narrative event
Blocking the channel	Ugrasen's men obstruct the flow of water	Sukhdev's rice and animals are endangered	Full evidence of the title dispute is absent
Waiting	Partition deed; priority accorded to a royal officer	The claim of right is repeatedly deferred	The order of three years, three weeks, and six weeks is unclear
Interrupted hearing	The lawyer raises a fresh technical objection	Time measured by the bowl becomes an instrument of dominance	The lawyer's independent counterposition is thin
Death	The incomplete words "Teacher, my daughter …"	A living person loses the chance to testify	Medical cause of death is not established
Reform of procedure	Waiting more than three days now confers priority	Keśava's institution changes	Land remains with the steward; no compensation
Narrative of remembrance	"Loth"; unnamed daughter; witness-tree	An unheard voice survives in oral memory	Folklore is not direct historical proof

The first state is Sukhdev's dependence upon the channel connected to the paired ponds for irrigating his half-bigha field. Second, Ugrasen's men block that channel and claim ancestral ownership; the field and the animals' water supply are endangered. Third, Sukhdev brings an old partition deed before the tribunal, but a marriage dispute, priority given to a government official, and the lawyer's technical objections prolong his hearing. Fourth, amid heat and scarcity of water, Sukhdev's field, his buffalo Kajrī, and his own body deteriorate. He begins the sentence "Master, my daughter …" but cannot finish and collapses in the assembly. Fifth, Budhuā intervenes, Keśava recognises the limits of the procedure, and the "Sukhdev Rule" is introduced, giving priority to someone who has waited more than three days. Sixth, despite this procedural reform, Sukhdev's land passes into the hands of Ugrasen's accountant, the dead man's daughter's name is absent from the record, and the folklore of the "Loth" preserves the memory of an unfinished reply. The new rule is not a

final resolution: the deceased man's unanswered grievance leaves the narrative open.

The Time of Judicial Procedure: An Equal Clock, Unequal Opportunity

The ghaṭikā instrument is a perforated brass bowl: after its allotted time has passed, it fills with water and sinks. In philosophical debate, an instrument meant to limit the otherwise endless elaboration of a speaker becomes a means of protecting the powerful in a village tribunal. Each technical question from the lawyer demands another interval measured by the clock; Sukhdev never fully obtains the opportunity to put forward his case. The chapter's social irony arises from the difference between the instrument's physically impartial movement and its institutional deployment. Saying, "If I hear Sukhdev first today," Keśava fears that the whole procedure will collapse. Yet giving people an equal duration and ensuring an equal opportunity to be heard are different things. The narrative's achievement lies in its refusal to locate the source of injustice solely in Ugrasen's personal wickedness: a voice trapped inside an approved system of rules may also suffer institutional violence.

The Twofold Structure of Time: A Three-Year Dispute and Six Weeks of Waiting

The text states that Sukhdev first appeared before the assembly three years earlier. Later it mentions a wait of three weeks and says that six weeks passed. On reading, these details do not produce an unambiguous personal calendar. Does the six-week period describe a final phase of a long-running dispute that began three years earlier, or does the narrative, while compressing time, leave out a connecting interval? The text offers no definitive answer. These uneven temporal signals should therefore be identified as a possible looseness in plotting, not concealed by an assertion of faultless chronology. Their emotional effect is nevertheless clear: every repetition of "Come tomorrow" consumes an irrecoverable part of bodily life. The humanly constructed time of the tribunal may be deferred or renewed; the field's drying season and the body approaching death cannot recover that time. This collision is the central temporal principle of the chapter.

Narrator, Focalisation, and Categories of Evidence

The opening "I" suggests a later narrator situated long after the events. This voice knows the future name of the village, the subsequent Sukhdev Rule, and even modern files and the corridors of law courts. Its range of knowledge exceeds that of the characters within the episode. Yet the narrator deliberately does not complete Sukhdev's final, unfinished sentence; the breadth of narrative authority is restrained at this point.

Waiting and bodily movement are seen through Budhuā's eyes; Keśava's inner difficulty emerges in the form of questions; and independent access to the minds of Ugrasen or the lawyer is slight. The description of the ghostly figure introduced with "it is said" belongs to the level of popular report, not to direct proof supplied by the narrator. Visible events, characters' utterances, retrospective judgements, and folklore must thus be treated as four distinct evidentiary positions.

Sukhdev Mahato: An Agent, a Man Kept Waiting, and the Failure to Speak

At the outset Sukhdev is not merely a victim. He possesses a field, a family, an old partition deed, a buffalo, and an explicit claim to a right. Arriving at the hearing on time, bringing his document, and appearing repeatedly are all active efforts. Yet the powerful man's objections govern the tribunal's agenda, and Sukhdev's role is gradually reduced from active claimant to silent petitioner. The image of a body sitting "in the sun, then in the shade" establishes an affinity with the roots of the peepal tree, to which the narrative returns near his death. The symbolism is painful: the man who sought justice for his livelihood becomes, in the end, a record of delay within the system of adjudication itself. The story, however, does not identify a medically verified direct cause of death. Heat, weakness resembling starvation, and prolonged waiting are causal circumstances presented by the narrative, not a clinically demonstrated diagnosis.

"My Daughter …": The Ethical Right of an Unfinished Sentence

At the final moment Sukhdev can say only, "Master, my daughter …" The rest is absent; the process of giving evidence breaks off in that absence. Socially, the omission is terrifying, because the dead man's daughter remains alive in the narrative world, yet her actual name never enters the village record. Early in the original episode she names her buffalo "Kajrī"; Kajrī is the buffalo's name. It would be wrong to infer that the daughter herself is named Kajrī. The contrast between an unnamed daughter and a named animal after the father's death is not a decorative juxtaposition but a question of archival selection. The author leaves the daughter incomplete within the final sentence; doing justice does not mean inventing her story at will. Nonetheless, a critical limitation remains: the daughter's own speech, her demand for recognition by name, and her social struggle after Sukhdev's death are not developed here. Depicting silence does not automatically restore a woman's voice.

Ugrasen and the Lawyer: In Whose Actions Does Injustice Reside?

Ugrasen Thakur's dominance rests upon land, debt, and the accounts kept by his agent. His men obstruct the channel; the lawyer questions

ownership and the witnesses to an old document. Asking a legal question is not itself an offence. Within this story, however, the sequence of questions, the assignment of priority before the hearing, and the consequences for the drying field confer a political meaning upon the procedure. The lawyer possesses the ability to obtain more time; Sukhdev suffers the destruction of his available time. A further limitation of opposing-character representation appears here: the reader is given insufficient access to Ugrasen's potentially relevant documents or to a source-based response on his behalf. The author sharpens the structure of injustice while permitting relatively little independent examination of the competing facts in the property dispute. This criticism does not exonerate the consequences ascribed to Ugrasen's obstruction; it identifies the nature of the evidence made available inside the text.

Keśava's Dilemma: From Compassionate Teacher to Culpable Administrator

Keśava comes from his teacher's tradition. He is compassionate, yet excessively bound by procedure. His own reasoning expresses the fear that "if order breaks, the entire system collapses." To call him a lifeless villain would therefore violate the fairness owed to the text. He believes in the supremacy of rules, is disturbed by the results of his own decisions, and eventually changes the rule. His question after Sukhdev dies—"Was I wrong?"—is narratively decisive. Because this introspective remorse becomes a practical decision, the episode is more than an emotionally charged lament. Nevertheless, changing a rule is no substitute for making restitution. There is no account here of an effort to return Sukhdev's field, to investigate the accountant's actions, or to secure a hearing for the daughter. The reform is an institutional adjustment rather than the established completeness of redress.

Budhuā's Duty as Witness: Water from the Conch and Powerlessness after Death

In previous chapters, Budhuā witnessed unfinished sentences and the limits of preserving the dead through memory. Here he sits beside the tribunal, notices Sukhdev's three weeks of waiting, challenges Keśava, and tries to offer water from his conch at the final moment. After death he attempts to bring the conch to Sukhdev's lips once more, although the narrator tells us that he knows water can no longer be swallowed. The failure of this action intensifies karuṇa-rasa: as in earlier tragedies, a witness may see everything yet be unable to recover lost time. Budhuā's principal proposition is that "Time itself is a luxury." This brings unequal circumstances of life into the apparently universal rule governing the tribunal's time. But even his obligation to bear witness does not confer the right to complete the

deceased person's unfinished intention word for word. Remembrance and representation are closely connected here, but they are not identical acts.

A Navya-Nyāya Test: Right, Reason, and Pervasion

The first subject of inquiry—the tribunal's water-clock procedure—must be distinguished from the property to be established: a fair hearing. If Keśava's argument is formulated as "An equal distribution of time necessarily produces justice," the text reveals a limiting condition: proficiency in speaking, unequal power, priority given to government officials, and repeated technical objections alter the result of allocation. Thus the necessary pervasion between "time has been limited" and "an equal hearing has been secured" is not established. Conversely, Sukhdev's production of an old partition deed constitutes evidence supporting his claim, but the mere existence of the document does not automatically yield a final decision concerning ownership: the full archival examination of the original dispute is unavailable in the text. Third, the subsequent transfer of the land to the accountant is powerful narrative evidence of the incomplete effect of reform. This discussion is a literary application of Navya-Nyāya's sensitivity to proof, not a verbatim aphorism ascribed to any historical teacher.

Water, Weather, and the Agency of More-than-Human Time

The thin flow of the Kamala-Balan, the drying shallow portion of the pond, obstruction of the channel, Kajrī the buffalo's emaciation, and rice ears failing to fill with grain are all active elements in the chapter's causal structure. The environmental crisis makes humanly imposed delays in judicial process harmful: in heat and water scarcity every additional day diminishes the prospects of the field's renewal. The river is thus not merely a background element of scenic beauty. Nor, however, can the river be treated as a moral agent deliberately perpetrating injustice. Social power operates decisively at the intersection of seasonal cycles and the use of a blocked water supply. The deep and shallow parts of the paired ponds register different natural conditions; social structure determines who controls the channel. The achievement of environmental narration lies in the causal interaction of these two levels, not in an easy judgement that either humanity alone or nature alone is guilty.

The People's Archive: The Witness-Tree, "Loth," and the Meaning of Absence

After Sukhdev's death, the story of a figure called "Loth," with its mouth half open beside the peepal, is introduced in the form "it is said." There is no direct evidence that the dead man actually returned. Folklore preserves an image of a person whose turn to speak never arrived. Budhuā's

observation redirects this fear towards the responsibility to listen. At the literary level of Navya-Nyāya's analysis of absence, two absences must be distinguished: the deceased man's missing final reply, and his daughter's missing name in the administrative record. Their causes, effects, and possible remedies differ. Folk memory preserves the vacancy left by the dead man's response, but does not insert a name into a legal register by itself. The peepal, as witness-tree, is an unofficial repository of folk history. Its power to remember is a symbolic meaning generated by human social practices, not independently documented historical testimony.

A Leap Across Centuries: From Local Suffering to the Modern "File"

The final prose passage abruptly compresses the passage of generations. The name "Garh Narikel" becomes established, the boundary of Channa Gachhi grows uncertain in popular belief, and the contemporary form of waiting emerges in "dates, files, and courthouse corridors." The narration joins a forward look from the present episode, historical summary, and commentary in the same movement. Its advantage is that Sukhdev's death no longer remains an isolated event of pathos but becomes an example of administrative injustice extending across time. Its limitation is that the concrete intermediate events of institutional change over hundreds of years depend largely upon the narrator's assertions. Did the peepal's roots spread as far as Channa Gachhi, or is Channa Gachhi itself an extension of that tree? The text acknowledges uncertainty with "or perhaps." This folklore must not be converted into a botanical fact. Mythic time and historical time touch here without becoming wholly identical.

Rasa, Suggestion, and Rhythm: The Regularity of Drops and a Voice Lost to Death

The opening saying, "Drop by drop falls water, drop by drop falls time," establishes a correspondence between physical drops of water and the span of human life. The final song again sets the counting of time against the preservation of names; the recurrence makes beginning and epilogue echo each other. The principal determinants of karuṇa-rasa are Sukhdev's death without a hearing, his unfinished sentence, and Budhuā's futile offering of water. The folktale of "Loth" stands at the boundary of fear and wonder, but does not dissolve the story's ethical centre into horror. As suggestion (dhvani), the water-clock's sinking bowl denotes not merely the expiration of time but the end of the chance to ask a question. A weakness in the song is its declaration that "the name remained firm" even though the daughter remains unnamed in the actual record. This contradiction should not be treated as the song's uncomplicated triumph; it may be accidental, or it may invite an ironic reading of the poetry.

The View of Videha's Parallel History: Named Rulers, an Unnamed Daughter

The conflict between a celebratory mainstream history and village memory is clear. Ugrasen's name, the priority of government functionaries, and the institution of the teacher receive documentary recognition; Sukhdev's daughter remains nameless. Folk song, Budhuā's sayings, the witness-tree, and "Loth" provide alternative forms of memory that challenge the administrative record. Yet it would also be mistaken to grant folklore the same evidentiary status as historical proof merely in the name of writing a parallel history. The claimant to a source, its narrator, its beneficiary, and the affected person rendered silent raise four separate questions. Sukhdev himself brings a partition deed: a written document is not always an instrument of oppression; it can be the principal basis for the rights of the weak. Without an opportunity to have that document read, however, its evidentiary possibility becomes practically worthless. The story therefore does not oppose writing as such. It opposes unequal access to written evidence.

Structural Achievements and Critical Limitations

The chapter's most notable achievement is to transform the ordinary visual object of a water clock into a sensitive argument concerning the political distribution of time. Keśava, who believes in the tribunal's rules, is not an enemy of humanity as such; nevertheless, his system produces harmful consequences. This distinction makes an institutional tragedy possible. Immediate reform after Sukhdev's death provides a narrative consequence, yet the loss of the field and the anonymity of the daughter prevent a declaration of success. Weaknesses include the missing chronological bridge between the first appearance three years earlier and the sequence of shorter periods culminating in six weeks; the insufficient independent examination of Ugrasen's documentary position; the absence of the deceased man's daughter's own voice; and the excessive summarisation of future social change. Without a precise medical account of death, a categorical formula such as "procedure directly killed him" is less faithful to the evidence than the interrelation of procedural delay, lack of water, and physical weakness. The philosophical background becomes productive when reasoning is examined in the real world of a drying field; this test is especially acute here.

Relation to the Next Chapter and the Question for the Study as a Whole

Chapter –91, "The Light of the Leatherworkers' Quarter," turns towards the village's leatherworking settlement, the social distribution of

knowledge, and a story associated with Gaṅgeśa. A question connects Sukhdev's obstructed hearing in Chapter −92 and the hierarchy of knowledge in Chapter −91: whose words are afforded the opportunity to count as evidence? Yet the distinct social circumstances of the next chapter should not be absorbed in a conclusion decided in advance. When these images recur in the larger trilogy, the actual transformations of Garh Narikel's ponds, peepal tree, river, Budhuā, and unnamed citizens must be compared. Whether "Loth," initially no more than folk memory of an unfinished sentence, becomes an autonomous narrative presence in later chapters also requires renewed examination of the original text. For now, the established conclusion is only this: equality in judicial procedure should be measured not merely by the equality of rules but by the time available for presenting evidence, the right to be heard, and the effective result of a decision.

Chapter −92: Register of Evidence Directly Checked against the Original

Opening saying: "Drop by drop falls water, drop by drop falls time."

Formal declaration: "An excerpt from a novel; moving away from dramatic form into narrative."

Narrator: "I am going to tell you today."

Former village name: "Narikel-Ghat."

Anticipation of the new name: "Garh."

Place: "Paired ponds."

Place of popular memory: "Witness-tree."

Working of the timepiece: "When the bowl fills up and sinks."

Claim to the channel: "This channel was made by my ancestors."

Order of the tribunal: "Tomorrow your case will be heard first."

Budhuā's objection: "This man has been coming for three weeks."

Keśava's reply: "Justice proceeds according to order, not desire."

Fear concerning procedure: "If order breaks, the entire system collapses."

Technical question: "First let it be made clear who originally owned the channel."

Further waiting: "Six weeks passed in this way."

Sukhdev's unfinished words: "Master, my daughter …"

Basis of Budhuā's question: "Time itself is a luxury."

New rule: "Sukhdev Rule."

Outcome: "Passed into the hands of Ugrasen's accountant."

Absence from the record: "Her real name never entered the village record."

Folktale: "Loth."

Duty of witness: "No witness has the right to complete an unfinished statement."

Connection to modernity: "Dates, files, and courthouse corridors."

Separate commentary after the drama: "The water-clock and the question of time in justice."

Critical Section 10 | Original Chapter −91 — The Light of the Leatherworkers' Quarter

"The Light of the Leatherworkers' Quarter" is the tenth original chapter in the period of the prehistory; its number in the novel's negative sequence is −91. The original contents give its opening as page 138 and the start of Chapter −90 as page 145, so its printed-page reference for this study is 138–144. These are page references supplied by the original Word document's contents, not the page numbers of the present critical study. The proportional figure in question is only an "intensity indicator," not an exact count of events. In this chapter, light measures not the capacity of eyes to see but society's willingness to recognise knowledge: why does a village that needs someone's labour treat that person's voice as unnecessary?

The Opening Narrative Position: From the Assembly Hall to the Western Drain

The story signals the village's passage from "Narikel-Ghat" to "Garh Narikel." The assembly hall has been constructed in permanent brick, and the prestige of the disciplines of justice and logic now takes institutional form. Yet the narrator immediately changes direction: "But for this story I must go to that part of the village" which the eyes of learned men do not reach. This choice of narration is a geographical reversal within the story-world. The central assembly hall and the marginalised "Marl-Gang" become two social centres of focalisation. The death inscribed in the name of the dried-up river is not merely a natural image. The river's shift away from the settlement, the greater distance to work, and the relegation of the settlement to the edge of the village all register a geography of life. The text does not establish the actual cause of the river's drying up, however; to declare it a particular historical offence of water management would exceed what the source supports.

"The Work the Village Needs": Untouchability within the Necessity of Labour

The leatherworkers' settlement is the site of drying hides, making drums and mṛdaṅgas, and stitching footwear. The village cannot function without these objects, yet it does not wish their makers to live near its own thresholds. The formulation "the work the village needs" exposes the coexistence of dependence upon labour and exclusion of the labourer. Economic reliance and social contempt stand side by side. The novel does not reduce "caste" to a scene of verbal abuse but situates it within everyday utility and the allocation of residential space. Nonetheless, the settlement's livelihood, market prices, debts, collective resistance, and internal

differences within the community receive no extended treatment here. The neglected quarter is represented principally through a few characters rather than a survey of its entire historical life. Criticism may identify this as a limitation while also taking account of the particular episode's restricted narrative form.

Ratnā: Bodily Care, Women's Knowledge, and the Initiation of Narrative Action

Ratnā is respected in the village for her experience with childbirth, medicinal plants, and patience, but that recognition has not been converted into written learning. She is the initial agent who brings an unnamed young man, trembling with fever, from outside into shelter. The story of a male philosopher proceeds not from his pronouncement of the word "evidence" but from a woman's immediate response to a vulnerable body. Without this human intervention, the opportunity for Gaṅgeśa's conversation with Mālatī would not arise. Ratnā nurses the patient for fifteen days. The text depicts the outcome but provides no measurement of the medical efficacy of her remedies. It would be equally inappropriate to describe her herbs as unverified supernatural healing or as a therapeutically established treatment by modern medical standards. Within the narrative, her care is causally indispensable. The mother's knowledge provides the structural foundation for the daughter's narrative emergence.

The Arrival of Gaṅgeśa: A Scholar Clutching a Palm-Leaf Manuscript, Defeated by His Own Body

The young man found lying beside an acacia tree holds a palm-leaf manuscript in his hand and will not release it even while unconscious. This visual image embodies another deprivation: extraordinary devotion to intellectual work together with the ordinary vulnerability of a body. Before his name is disclosed, we hear of his fever, hunger, exhaustion, and indistinct muttering of "evidence." Various stories are said to circulate about his birth, childhood intelligence, and family lineage, but the narrator himself cannot determine whether they are true or merely rumours. The critic must not remove that uncertainty and construct a historical biography. The young man's intellectual prestige is not established in advance; the reader reaches him through care and conversation. This reversal unsettles the conventional centre of scholarly greatness: first the dependence of a human being upon others, then the eventual fame of the author of a treatise.

Mālatī's Question: Sincerity, Truth, and the Unresolved Relation to Testimony

Sixteen-year-old Mālatī hears the feverish Gaṅgeśa's muttering and asks how a speaker's words can be false if there is no intention to lie in the speaker's mind. The question offers a valuable ethical challenge: instead of judging through caste prejudice, consider the speaker's disposition. Yet the philosophical limits of the question are also clear. A false utterance is not invariably deceitful; a person who is sincerely convinced can nevertheless say something mistaken. Ethical sincerity and objectively true cognition cannot therefore be equated. Here the chapter proposes an independent possibility for knowledge against social prejudice, but does not complete an entire theory of verbal testimony. Mālatī's question is not merely a proclamation of personal dignity: it places pressure upon society's standards for assessing knowledge, extending to the principle "whoever the speaker may be." The nuances of āptatā, or the trustworthiness relevant to testimony in Navya-Nyāya, and of the conditions that produce valid cognition still require separate examination.

The Drum Illustration: The Quality of an Instrument and the Truth of an Utterance

Mālatī draws upon the making of drums by her father, Somar. If the leather is not stretched properly, even a skilled player will produce a distorted sound; if it is stretched correctly, an ordinary drum can produce a clearly audible note. The direct basis of the example lies in the physical structure of an instrument, the artisan's observation, and the audible result. Mālatī's knowledge is therefore not merely an emotive metaphor but a causal test arising from experience. A complete pervasion between the drum's "correct note" and the "truth" of an utterance, however, is not established: the fitness of a physical instrument does not determine every question concerning the meaning, intention, and factual correspondence of human speech. The drum example reveals necessary physical and social conditions in the production of knowledge, not the entire set of sufficient conditions. Missing this distinction risks mistaking the novel's illustrative analogy for an accepted universal theorem of philosophical science.

Gaṅgeśa's Response: Intellectual Recognition or Excessive Simplification?

Gaṅgeśa interprets Mālatī's statement as meaning that reliability should rest on the correctness of the instrument or means (karaṇa), not the lineage of the speaker. He declares that a question that had held him up for three years has been solved in a single breath. The strength of the episode is that the learned character relinquishes his class-based prestige and listens

to a new source of questioning; eligibility for knowledge is not established by birth. But a critical problem remains. Does the immediate resolution of a complicated problem of verbal testimony in the Tattvacintāmaṇi through a single drum illustration constitute deliberate dramatic compression or an excessively easy solution to a philosophical conflict? The dialogue contains no complete sequence of counterarguments; it presents a moment of sudden illumination. That illumination succeeds as an emotional turning point within the story, but it is not proof of a conclusion in classical scholarship. The original text uses a form rendered as "ābtā," whose precise relationship to the technical concept of āptatā requires independent textual scrutiny. It would be hazardous to infer a strict technical conclusion from the sentence's general sense alone.

Fifteen Days and Two Years: The Pace of Narrative Time

Ratnā's fifteen days of nursing pass in compressed summary, while the exchange of questions and answers between Mālatī and Gaṅgeśa becomes extended direct dialogue. Afterwards, Gaṅgeśa's visits to the house and the settlement of the marriage within two years are again expressed in condensed narrative time. These three phases—the period of treatment, the moment of intellectual awakening, and the long formation of a relationship—receive unequal development. The narrator pauses at the point of conjunction to create a scene while passing over changes in everyday life through composite sentences. The advantage is that intellectual exchange and resistance to caste prejudice occupy the foreground. The limitation is that readers see relatively little of Mālatī's own decision-making, Gaṅgeśa's personal inner conflict, or the two years in which mutual respect developed. The decision to marry takes shape in the story, but most of the relationship's social and emotional process remains a summary.

Opposition to Marriage: Exclusion from Prestige by Institutions of Knowledge

Opposition from the Brahmin quarter is not merely a matter of conventional insult. The threat is that Gaṅgeśa will no longer be invited to philosophical debates, scholars will not recognise him as a witness, and his books will be excluded from schools. These acts constitute three levels of institutional exclusion: admission to the assembly, recognition of a person's testimony, and circulation of knowledge. The structure transforms marriage from a private emotional decision into a public question of the right to participate in knowledge. Nevertheless, the text presents the Brahmin quarter as almost uniformly opposed. It does not develop a sympathetic figure, a doubtful young scholar, or an alternative institutional procedure within that community. This sharpens the social

conflict but opens less of the opponents' varied inner lives. Such criticism does not deny the existence of oppression; it measures the internal complexity of the scene's construction.

Budhuā's Arrival: Long Memory and Anticipatory Testimony

Budhuā's arrival beside the peepal witness-tree at the moment of Gaṅgeśa's uncertainty joins the prehistory's separate tragedies within one circle of testimony. The conch and worn rope in his hands are returning signs from earlier chapters; they now identify the witness rather than serving as inert souvenirs. Budhuā compares the lifespan of prestige gained through disputation with the possible longer life of knowledge arising from labour. His prediction that people will read Gaṅgeśa's treatise but forget Mālatī's drum is a flash-forward whose truth the later summary of the story promptly demonstrates. By the standards of realistic history, Budhuā's extraordinary longevity would be problematic; under the novel's magical and folkloric arrangement of memory he is a figure of testimony crossing generations. Yet when the character explains how he has heard so many stories by saying that "the wind tells me many things," the claim is poetic, not direct archival evidence.

How Far Does a Witness's Authority Extend? The Promise to Preserve Mālatī's Name

Budhuā says that society will turn Gaṅgeśa's marriage into a story of charity rather than a story of justice; he wishes to preserve Ratnā's and Mālatī's names on another page. This is an extremely important turn in the question of representation. Instead of constructing a story about the generosity of a man placed socially above others, the novel demands recognition of the intellectual collaboration of working women. Yet "preserving a name" and "enabling a person to tell her own story" are not the same thing. We do not receive Ratnā's direct autobiographical account or an extended account of Mālatī speaking after her marriage; Budhuā's promise remains the principal means of preservation. The text employs an ethics of protective witness. Its critical challenge is how far a woman's voice still depends upon a story told by a male witness even after protection has been promised. Both the achievement and limitation of the chapter emerge from this question.

Marriage, the Composition of a Treatise, and a Great Leap in Chronology

After the resistance to marriage, the narrative states that Gaṅgeśa composed his treatise over the next twenty years, and it came to be taught in every school. A major historical outcome is compressed into very little scenic space. The narrative result is readily understood: the social source of

knowledge is forgotten, while the male author of the treatise becomes celebrated. Yet the praise that the work equals "twelve thousand treatises" is an ornamental measure of philosophical greatness, not an actual mathematical standard. Across this long period, there are few independent scenes of changes in Ratnā and Somar's livelihood, Mālatī's intellectual companionship, the room in which the treatise was composed, or its reception in schools. The summary avoids making the story purposeless, but leaves many possible events of a biographical narrative undeveloped.

The Status of History: Fiction Explicitly Acknowledged by Its Author

A separate explanatory presentation begins near the chapter's end under the heading "Stories and Illustrations Associated with Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya." It explicitly states that the names, characters, and circumstances of Mālatī, Ratnā, and Somar are products of imagination and are not verified by historical documents. This declaration must be regarded as a strict boundary within the present criticism. The historical Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and his Tattvacintāmaṇi belong to an actual intellectual tradition, but this particular account of a family is a possible fictional reconstruction. Even the mention of a popular story about Gaṅgeśa's marriage to a leatherworking woman does not constitute confirmation of a historical marriage. The author himself draws a distinction between oral tradition and literary construction. Ignoring that admission and presenting the story as historical proof would weaken the work's own perspective of parallel history.

A Dialectical Reading of History: Tantric Blessing versus Education through Labour

In popular tradition, Gaṅgeśa's intellectual awakening is associated with a Tantric practitioner or the grace of the goddess Kālī; the present narrative constructs a possible contribution from the experience, care, and dialogue of a leatherworking family. The author does not claim to have proved that the first account is historically false; he opens a second, imaginative, parallel possibility. The story of divine grace and the story of human collaboration distribute ethical significance across social memory in different ways. The Tantric account makes the thinker an exceptional, isolated genius; Mālatī's account renders the genesis of knowledge relational. Yet the narrative should not present this as "the definite true source that has been suppressed." Doing so would substitute a desired past for missing records and violate the discipline of evidence. The strength of literary alternative history lies in the transparency of its imaginative construction, not in concealing gaps in proof.

Ratnā's *Chhauṅkī-Sabhā*: An Informal Institution of Knowledge

At evening meetings beside Marl-Gang, women exchange experiences of illness, childbirth, domestic violence, village injustice, and people's private conduct in their chhauṅkī-sabhās. This institution is a collective activity rather than a single occasion of instruction. Regular conversation, repeated gatherings, and the transmission of knowledge from generation to generation constitute its structure. The absence of classical terminology is not evidence of ignorance; it marks a different practice of knowledge. Yet the workings of decision-making in these gatherings, their resolution of external disputes, examples of successful and failed treatments, and organised plans for confronting male resistance are depicted only sparingly. "Assembly" undoubtedly names an institution, but a detailed examination of its operating procedures is deferred to possible later episodes.

Naming Women "Witches": Transforming Knowledge into Fear

The narrator makes clear the process by which women's knowledge, refused entry into the community's written record, comes to be labelled "witchcraft" and its practitioners "witches." Here naming prepares the ground for violence: those who refuse to acknowledge a form of knowledge may turn it into a threatening power. Nonetheless, deriving all popular beliefs from one cause would be an insufficient explanation of social history. This chapter does not give a developed account of the specific accusations made by those using the label, the system of punishments, or the process of violence. It is therefore more appropriate to regard the accusation as a narrative thread pointing towards future social conflict. The transformation between the chhauṅkī-sabhā and the designation "witch" is attested on the levels of metaphor and communal memory within the story, not as a universal rule concerning every historical settlement or group of women.

Environmental Narration: Marl-Gang, the Acacia, the Peepal, and Folk Memory

Three places perform different narrative functions. The dry course of Marl-Gang becomes a zone of environmental deprivation and social separation for the working settlement; the shade of the acacia provides the initial scene of the injured Gaṅgeśa's fallen body; and the peepal witness-tree centres Budhuā's promise and intergenerational memory. The text does not regard the tree as a historical document equivalent to a human witness; through metaphor it becomes a bearer of memory. More-than-human objects guide the direction of the story, while its decisive choices are made by Ratnā, Mālatī, Gaṅgeśa, Budhuā, and social groups. The drying of the river constructs the narrative place; the young man's

treatment, the question, and the marriage produce social change. This distinction does not diminish the environment's significance but clarifies the levels of agency within the narrative.

Language, Focalisation, and the Narrator's Ethical Intervention

Saying "I must go …," the narrator leads readers from the institutional centre into the neglected quarter. Indirect omniscient narration, dialogic scenes, and signals of reported folk tradition such as "it is said" then alternate. In the drum illustration Mālatī speaks for herself; Gaṅgeśa's scholarly response recognises her experience; the subsequent historical summary returns to the decisive authority of the narrator. This movement produces a tension between the illumination of the woman's voice and the dominance of male exposition. At times the narrator demands the reader's ethical assent in advance, giving opposing characters insufficient opportunity for independent thought. Yet acknowledging that the story is fictional does not make a modern novel unreliable; rather, it makes readers aware of the differing truth claims of its narrative levels.

A Navya-Nyāya Examination: Subject, Reason, Limiting Condition, and Absence

The first inference—"A person's caste is high; therefore the speaker is trustworthy"—lacks a demonstrated pervasion. No necessary association between birth status and the truth of knowledge has been established in the original. The second inference—"The drum is properly stretched; therefore the speaker's statement is true"—has a limiting condition: the physical production of a sound and the factual correspondence of a proposition require different kinds of grounds. Third, trustworthy testimony, sincere intention, and actual truth are related without being wholly identical. Mālatī's example breaks the caste-based barrier to considering a speaker's words; it does not terminate every classical problem concerning verbal testimony. The absence of Mālatī's historical contribution from records proves neither that such a contribution was impossible nor that the particular event certainly occurred. The delimitation must remain clear: "Within this novel's story-world Mālatī inspires the thinker" is an established narrative proposition; "Exactly this event occurred in history" is a distinct and unestablished claim. Such clarity of limits protects the scholarly integrity of parallel history.

Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti, and the Test of Appropriateness

The opening saying compares "the lamp of the quarter and the lamp of the palace," both fed by the same oil, as a metaphor for equal intellectual potential. Comparing a drum's sound with the "truth" of a philosophical treatise creates an oblique displacement akin to vakrokti: a difficult

technical question finds expression in the language of popular craftsmanship. Karuṇa-rasa is present in the nursing of the feverish young man, Mālatī's fear of humiliation, and the forgetting of Ratnā's name. The heroic impulse appears in the decision to withstand opposition to the marriage. Yet the closing song proclaims, "Light shines equally," even as the plot shows that equal illumination has not become equal social recognition. This opposition lends the song an ironic resonance. Read only as a song of victory, it would cover over the chapter's wound. A further question of appropriateness concerns whether the intermediate stages of conflict between severe social hostility and the rapid success of the marriage receive sufficient dramatic development.

A Causal Register of Events and a Genuine Test of Event Density

Narrative moment	Textual basis or actor	Change of state	Remaining critical issue
Division of space	Assembly hall versus Marl-Gang	The focal centre shifts to a neglected quarter	Reason for the river drying is unspecified
Rescue	Ratnā and Somar; fever-stricken Gaṅgeśa	The intellectual traveller depends upon material care	The medical efficacy of the remedy is unproven
Question and illustration	Mālatī's words and the drum	Caste loses its assumed place in Gaṅgeśa's inference	No universal pervasion between an instrument and truth
Institutional opposition	Brahmin quarter; the decision to marry	Threats of boycott of disputation and school	Opponents' psychology is underdeveloped
Witness's declaration	Budhuā, the conch, and the witness-tree	Pledge to protect the names of Mālatī and Ratnā	Limits of preserving another person's name
Long-term outcome	Marriage, treatise, forgotten source	Philosophical prestige separates from memory of labour	Twenty years compressed into a rapid summary
Alternative communal institution	Ratnā's *chhauṅkī-sabhā*	Women's experience becomes collective knowledge	The assembly's procedures are only briefly developed

At least six different changes of state can be distinguished: (a) the fever-stricken Gaṅgeśa's arrival in the leatherworkers' settlement; (b) recovery from his immediate medical crisis through Ratnā's care; (c) a shift in Gaṅgeśa's intellectual position through Mālatī's question; (d) institutional caste resistance prompted by the decision to marry; (e) Budhuā's promise to preserve witness and memory; and (f) the forgetting of Mālatī after the marriage and the treatise's subsequent prestige, alongside the women's alternative memory of assemblies. In fact, the later part of the chapter compresses twenty years of composition and long-term popular memory into very few paragraphs. The extension of story-time is not the same thing as densely realised scenic events. The main emotional turning point is the exchange concerning the drum. The eventual institutional consequence—the women's gatherings—endures through informal recurrence rather than as a formally enacted rule.

Achievement: A Bold Narrative of a Parallel Genealogy of Knowledge

The chapter's most concrete achievement is to make Ratnā and Mālatī indispensable agents in the production of knowledge rather than decorative subplots in a famous man's life. The practical labour of the leatherworkers' quarter, medicinal care, the experience of making drums, and the regular gatherings of women are all joined to questions of proof, teaching, and the writing of history. Compared with classical prestige, the more fruitful question becomes not "Into which lineage was this person born?" but "What tests are available within this person's experience?" The return of the witness-tree provides a temporal bridge between earlier struggles over the names of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sukhdev and this distinct problem of women's knowledge.

Limitations: Compressed History, Hasty Philosophical Conclusions, and Partial Female Speech

Four principal limitations emerge. First, the scene in which a single illustration by Mālatī is declared to resolve a scholarly problem that detained Gaṅgeśa for three years makes philosophical deliberation exceedingly abrupt. Second, the conflict over marriage gives relatively little room to diverse voices within the opposing community or to a sustained interior account of Mālatī's choices. Third, the twenty years of writing the treatise and the development of its scholarly reception proceed through extremely rapid summary, so the everyday cooperation involved in making knowledge receives little scenic demonstration. Fourth, despite the women's chhauṅkī-sabhā, responsibility for remembering Ratnā and Mālatī ultimately depends upon Budhuā as a male witness. These weaknesses do not negate the novel's basic social intervention. They clarify the difference between the significance of its ethical ambition and the means by which that ambition is realised in narrative form.

A Bridge towards Chapter −90: The Longevity of Memory and the Cost of Witnessing

The promise to preserve Mālatī's and Ratnā's names immediately before the next chapter, "Budhuā's Water Burial," is important. Hulāsā's unfinished sentence, Jīvantī's manuscript, Sukhdev's hearing, and now the neglected knowledge of leatherworking women accumulate one after another within Budhuā's memory. This burden may become the ethical precondition of the next chapter's narrated death or transformation, but the event of that chapter must not be assumed as certain from this section alone. The independent judgement on the present chapter is that literature can raise the question of artisans, caregivers, and unnamed women interlocutors missing from the history of classical scholarship, but must

not present imaginative reconstruction as an indisputable transcript of history. Here "light" is not complete justice; it is an unresolved dispute over the right to the illumination of knowledge.

Chapter −91: Register of Evidence Directly Compared with the Original

Shift of location: "But for this story I must go to that part of the village."

Name of the river: "Marl-Gang."

Neglected labour: "The work the village needs."

Mālatī's father: "Somar, the leatherworker."

Ratnā's distinctive quality: "Patience."

Words spoken by the feverish Gaṅgeśa: "Evidence … without evidence … how …"

Uncertainty of oral tradition: "Whether all these stories were true or rumours."

Length of treatment: "Gaṅgeśa struggled with fever for fifteen days."

End of Mālatī's question: "Whoever the speaker may be."

Condition of the drum: "If the leather is not properly stretched."

Claim about the drum: "Then the drum speaks in a false voice."

Definition of the means: "The correctness of the karaṇa (instrument or means)."

Recognition of knowledge: "You have told a story of Nyāya."

Time to marriage: "Within two years."

Question raised in opposition: "Will he marry a leatherworking woman?"

Budhuā's memory: "Sixty years ago there was an Objector."

Budhuā's self-description: "I am a servant."

Distant witness's explanation: "The wind tells me many things."

Prediction concerning intellectual cooperation: "It will be present on every page of your book."

Anticipation of forgetting: "They will forget Mālatī's drum."

Justice against charity: "They will turn it into a story of charity, not of justice."

Focus of the promise: "Ratnā's and Mālatī's names."

Period of composition: “Over the next twenty years.”

Alternative account of intellectual origins: “Through a Tantric practitioner's favour or the blessing of goddess Kālī.”

Women's different institution: “They had established an assembly among themselves.”

Threatening designation: “Witch.”

Voice of popular memory: “A quiet voice is a protected voice.”

Image in the song: “The lamp of the quarter and the lamp of the palace—the same oil burns in both.”

Explicit paratextual limitation: “Imagined; not established by historical documents.”

Status of the alternative possibility: “Presents an alternative, parallel possibility.”

Critical Section 11 | Original Chapter −90 — Budhua's Water Burial

"Budhua's Water Burial" is the eleventh original chapter of the period of prehistory; its number in the negative sequence is −90. The original novel's contents place its beginning on page 145 and the next chapter, −89, on page 152. The printed page range of the original edition is accordingly 145–151, distinct from the pagination of this cumulative criticism. Treating the ratio between these numbers as a count of events would be a methodological error. In fact, several changes of state involving memory, decision, the transfer of objects, and folklore are arranged around one major event of disappearance. Reading the chapter also brings a further question: how does personal memory become a social archive, and to what extent can narrative technique recast the disappearance of a body as a form of rebirth?

The Weight of the Previous Ten Chapters: The Life of a Witness Becomes a Story

From Chapters −100 to −91, Budhua has appeared as a witness to philosophical debates, unfinished utterances, deaths, women's labour, and the neglect of justice. Here the narrator makes him the centre of the story for the first time. The village has changed; the assembly building has twice collapsed and been rebuilt; Ācārya Vardhamāna, the seventh-generation successor in Keśava's tradition, now presides over the assembly. Yet Budhua is still alive. His extraordinary longevity immediately takes the narrative beyond the standard of a realistic biography and into the domain of folkloric wonder. This change is not abrupt: the conch-and-silver illusion in the first chapter, the unfinished speech of the dead, and the vow connected with the witness-tree return here as long-range narrative threads. The achievement of the plot lies in these connections, each recollection reactivating an unresolved ethical question from an earlier story. Nevertheless, using an indefinitely living witness to join several historical ages also provides the narrator with a convenient bridge. The reader must accept the unnatural convention on which it rests.

The Village in Time and Space: Assembly Hall, Pond, Peepal, and Maral-Gang

The changes in Garh Narikel are described at both social and environmental levels. The construction and destruction of the assembly hall signify the transience of institutions. The paired ponds remain, but their deep section is said to have grown deeper. Increasing depth attributed merely to silt and rainfall is not a self-evident environmental explanation:

sedimentation can ordinarily reduce depth. This is an internal question about the environmental description, which should not be received as a demonstrated hydrological fact. The peepal roots reach towards the water; four generations of Ratnā's family have worked in the leatherworkers' settlement of Maral-Gang. Their contribution to the physical care associated with childbirth continues, although the Brahmin settlement does not publicly acknowledge it. Inequality thus persists across the passing of time; social history is not simply a line of progress. Pond, tree, and settlement are not inert backdrops but a geography of communal division and means of preserving memory.

Unnatural Longevity: The Announcement of a Rule and the Reader's Contract

"And Budhua was still alive" is a short sentence bearing the weight of the entire temporal transition. The continuing existence of one person across seven generations cannot be reconciled with ordinary biological realism. The narrator does not explain this discrepancy by a medical miracle; the villagers accept it as naturally as the peepal or the pond. The rule of this unnatural narrative is made legitimate through the collective belief of its fictional world. Critically, what matters is that the text admits realistic caste inequality and extraordinary longevity in the same breath. This creates the possibility of magical realism, though the presence of an exceptional event is not sufficient for a definitive generic classification; the stability of this rule must be tested in other parts of the narrative. Treating the extraordinary lifespan as historical proof would destroy the work's imaginative convention.

The Recurrence of Names: Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā

Budhua can no longer walk. Sitting beneath the peepal, with the conch and rope beside him, he speaks a name to each passer-by. Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā: these four names join the preceding chapters' social and ethical lines. Their repetition is not purposeless information; it is an act of resistance to forgetting. Each refers to a distinct unfinished question: Hulāsā's incomplete sentence, Jīvantī's water-bound manuscript, Sukhdev's delayed justice, and Ratnā's unrecorded contribution. Yet the selection of names remains under Budhua's authority as witness. Other neglected people, especially unnamed collective labourers, may again be excluded by that same process of selection. Both the compassion and the selective power of witnessing must be considered together.

The Winter Scene: Environmental Time and a Pause Before Death

Bitter cold, the thin flow of the Kamla-Balan, buffaloes out of the pond, absent herons, and the still surface of the water are more than an

ornamental list of seasonal details. Narrative pace suddenly slackens, as though nature were preparing an empty space in which the approaching event might be heard. But the imagery does not establish that the river has physically frozen: its current is described as "cold as ice," not as actual ice. The withdrawal or endurance of nonhuman life establishes the atmosphere preceding death. The text does not demonstrate a necessary causal relation between weather and Budhua's decision. Winter is consonant with his state of mind, not the sole reason for his resolve. The pause in narrative time prepares the reader for the transformation of tree, water, and shadow.

Raghunāth's Question and the Disjunction of Time in Dialogue

Raghunāth, a young disciple of Ācārya Vardhamāna, asks Budhua his age. Rather than answer with a number, Budhua remembers the opening scene: the row of coconut trees, the peepal, the pond, and the debate about mistaking a conch for silver. Raghunāth exclaims, "Vācaspati Miśra?" and thereby registers the separation of ages. The actual dramatic function of the exchange is not to provide Budhua's age but to bring home the seemingly impossible extent of the narrative's timescale. The question seeks an external calculation; the response gives lived memory. The order of telling and the time of the story are thus visibly different. The reader recalls the earliest chapters, whereas the village's new generation encounters the same memory as a marvel. Raghunāth briefly voices historical disbelief, but his subsequent investigation is not developed as a scene; this limits the intellectual counterposition within the story.

Body and Memory: The Ethical Crisis of a Mortal Medium

Budhua's decisive self-recognition—"Not in my body, but in my memory"—turns the arithmetic of age into an ethical experience. Memory is not simply an honour to him; it is a burden. The fear that four unheard lives will disappear with his failing body becomes a source of grief. At this moment memory is an archive lodged in an individual, with no complete substitute in the community's written or institutional records. The narrator explicitly says that these things are not carved on a stone or written in any book. Yet earlier chapters contain books, rules, manuscripts, and a chamber of memory. "In no book" is therefore more reasonably read as a claim about the inadequate recording of these four people's lived truths than as the literal absence of every relevant document. A rigid generalisation would create tension with the prehistory's own archival motifs.

The Decision and its Causality: Self-Sacrifice or the Risk of Self-Erasure?

After Raghunāth leaves, Budhua senses that death is near and asks who will preserve these names if memory ends with him. The next scene shows him carrying the conch and rope towards the pond. The narrative progression is clear: bodily weakness → recognition of an archival absence → an urgent desire to protect names → entry into water. But this sequence does not establish that water burial is the only available means of preservation. Dictating his memories to the young Raghunāth, passing them on to the leatherworking women's evening circle, or preparing a public register are possibilities the story does not examine independently. Criticism must treat Budhua's entry into water as a difficult episode of individual dignity, mortality, and ethical autonomy, without proclaiming it a necessary or exemplary technique for preserving memory. The artistic effect is poignant, but the causal necessity of the purported solution remains unproved.

An Echo of Conch and Silver: The Beginning Returns at the End

Moonlight spreads "like silver" upon the pond. The conch-and-silver debate from the opening chapter has now changed from an epistemological illustration into an emotional echo. Budhua clasps the conch to his chest; it is no longer merely the object in an example of illusion, but an object that bears memory. This symbolic return closes a cycle extending across roughly ten chapters. What began as a question about visual cognition ends as a question about the existence of names and memories. Nevertheless, the silver's glitter offers no certain proof of truth. Readers are required both to trust memory and to acknowledge its limits. The "water burial" of the novel's title is not here a final solution of philosophical nondualism but a narrative means of retaining unfinished justice within folklore.

Four Addresses: Preserving the Rights of Unfinished Speech

Before entering the water, Budhua addresses four people in succession. He refuses to complete Hulāsā's "I…" because he has no right to do so: this is a significant restraint upon the witness. He pledges to answer Jīvantī's "To bear witness to a book is also…" through his own actions; his recollection of Sukhdev's daughter, buffalo, and partition document stands in for claims erased by an institution; and the imagined inscription of Ratnā's name upon water grants symbolic visibility to labour excluded from scholastic books. These addresses are different in tone: respect for silence, practical continuation of an unfinished promise, testimony concerning a right, and restoration of recognition to women's work. Their variety prevents the ethics of witnessing from becoming a mere slogan. Still, there

is a delicate ethical distinction between "completing" Jīvantī's utterance and declining to "complete" Hulāsā's; an explicit distinction by the narrator might have rendered the novel's ethics of testimony still clearer.

Scene, Summary, and Narrative Duration

The opening compresses the passing of generations into a paragraph: a summary of historical duration. Time opens into a scene in the exchange between Raghunāth and Budhua; at the pond, the four addresses unfold almost at the speed of actual speech. The moment of entry into water becomes slower and more finely detailed: the gleam of the surface, the peepal's apparent inclination, the stilling of the wind, the sight of stars, the act of sitting, and the calming of ripples. The morning search is a brief scene, after which centuries of folk tradition are compressed into rapid summary. This alternation of expansion and compression focuses the reader's emotional attention upon the entry into the pond. The control of discourse-time is effective, although the social processes attending death or disappearance after the dramatic climax are disposed of with very little evidence.

Focalisation: From Budhua's Inward Fear to the Village's External Folklore

The opening presents the village, generations, social groups, and institutions through a narrator's extensive external perspective. In the middle, Budhua's private fear that names will die is represented from within. His feeling that the water is not cold as he enters it also indicates internal access by the narrator. At morning, the perspective shifts to the fishermen's search and Vardhamāna's public reaction. Finally, through the formula "people began to say," an unidentified collective source gains the authority to tell the story. These changes of focalisation alter the epistemic status of information: Budhua's experience is narrated within the fictional world; the discovery of the conch and rope belongs to the morning's direct search; shadows and whispers are communal claims; and "twelve hundred years" is a symbolic tradition. To make all of them equivalent historical evidence would erase distinctions between narrative levels.

The Absent Crocodile: A Major Causal Gap in the Title

The opening proverb says, "The crocodile took the body and left the name." Yet the extended scene of entry into water shows no crocodile. In the morning the fishermen find neither body nor footprints nor signs of struggle. The directly narrated event therefore does not establish "a crocodile attack," "a body carried away by a crocodile," or any definite cause of death. The proverb may be read as prior folk explanation, symbol, or the language of communal grief. This difference offers an artistic

advantage: the unseen crocodile becomes a source of uncertainty and dread in the water. Yet the absence of scenic confirmation of the title's apparently concrete assertion is also a legitimate critical question. In a novel concerned with social justice, inquiry, and proof, the distance between direct evidence and communal verdict is especially consequential.

Nonhuman Activity: Levels of Agency in Tree, Water, and Animal

It "seemed as though" the peepal roots inclined towards Budhua; the wind stopped "as if" holding its breath; the pond shone like silver. Through these recurring similes, the tree and water become sensitive witnesses without the text offering realistic proof of their consciousness. The nonhuman environment serves three functions: the staging of emotion, symbolic co-witness, and vehicle of memory. Buffaloes, herons, silt, cold, and trees make ecological life part of the story's domain. Nevertheless, Budhua's decision arises from a recognisably human ethical uncertainty; the pond does not compel it. The subtlety of environmental narration lies in preserving this distinction: water makes the event possible, and the tree becomes the site of recollection, but human responsibility for choosing is not wholly transferred to nonhuman objects.

The Morning Search: Material Evidence and the Missing Body

The fishermen find the conch and rope. These are not merely an imaginative flourish of the narrator: within the fictional world they are objects directly recovered by characters. But their discovery does not itself prove Budhua's manner of death or a supernatural transformation. Failure to find a body is neither evidence that death did not occur nor complete physical proof that it did. Folk memory operates in precisely this gap. Ācārya Vardhamāna places the conch at the foot of the peepal, beginning a kind of public memorial practice. His statement "Budhua has not died" should be read as an expression of reverential ethical belief, not as a medical or historical conclusion. The types of evidence—object, absence, and interpretation—are clearly distinct.

A Navya-Nyāya Examination of Evidence: Subject, Reason, Pervasion, and Fallacy

For the first proposition, "The crocodile carried away Budhua's body," the requisite direct signs are absent; the proverb alone cannot supply a valid reason. For the second, "Memory of Budhua remains alive near the peepal," the evidence consists of folk utterances, children hearing his stories, and public preservation of the conch: these support a tradition of memory, not the material existence of a ghost. For the third, "No body was found, therefore he is immortal," absence supplies an insufficient reason and entails the possibility of a fallacious inference. Fourth, "twelve

hundred years" may signify memorable antiquity but is not adequate evidence for a specific historical chronology. A delimiting condition is necessary: within the novel's folklore, immortal presence is accepted; in the material historical world, the conclusion would require separate proof. Recognising this distinction does not disparage imaginative narration; it identifies the different truth regime under which it operates.

"Twelve Hundred Years": Symbolic Time and Internal Chronology

Towards the end, the narrator explicitly says that people first spoke of hundreds of years, then a thousand, and eventually chose the memorable rounded figure "twelve hundred years." A concluding note places Budhua's water burial roughly four or five hundred years after Vācaspati's time. It would therefore be a mistake to treat twelve hundred as his exact biological lifespan or an exact interval. The story discloses this divergence rather than concealing it. The distinction between mythical time and documentary time reminds the reader that folklore is a method of conserving meaning, not a clock for measurement. Nevertheless, if another part of the novel employs the number as though it were precise chronology, a reader may be confused. Identifying this distinction does not mean automatically finding a defect; it specifies the conditions of the narrator's declared temporal convention.

From Memory to Ghost: An Institution of Preservation or the Sanctification of a Person?

Reports of a shadow beneath the peepal and whispers pronouncing names send the story into the circulation of oral culture. Children hear the old names, while the identity of the storyteller becomes indistinct. A memorial site becomes a transmitter of narrative. Budhua's ghost is produced through collective naming, but a question remains: to what extent do living members of society fulfil their judicial and archival obligations? The worship of the names of Hulāsā and Sukhdev is not the same as redressing the injustice that remained unresolved during their lives. If the work merely declares that a compassionate ghost has preserved every name, present social responsibility risks becoming lighter. Yet the recurrence of each person's unfinished story insists that memory is not a substitute for justice, but a record of its outstanding debt.

The Witness-Tree and the Perspective of Videha's Parallel History

Around the witness-tree gather stories left outside royal records, prestigious manuscripts, and histories of victors. Hulāsā's words, Jīvantī's book, Sukhdev's land, and Ratnā's labour are recalled to construct a tradition of names excluded from accepted prestige. This is the critical possibility of parallel history. Still, what "people say" cannot automatically

be treated as a solid factual account opposed to official history. Questions of evidence are not obstacles to this ethical enterprise but a fundamental tension within the work itself. Criticism of an archival system that erases names becomes stronger when it improves the possibility of recording them, not when it removes the need for direct evidence. The peepal is an alternative place for the authority of memory, not a complete court of justice or an authenticated archive.

Folk Song: Karuṇa-rasa and the Compression of a Complex Event

The closing song opposes the body going into the water to the name surviving in the village's mind. It gives the episode an emotional conclusion; communal singing transforms an individual witness into shared memory. Alongside compassion, an intimation of tranquillity is present. The parallel between a "deep pond" and a "deep name" is an oblique transformation of measure: physical depth becomes a figure for ethical endurance. Yet the song settles the event in a firm phrase, whereas the prose supplies no conclusive proof about a body or a crocodile. The song expresses collective belief, not a forensic finding. Keeping that distinction in view preserves both its poetic achievement and the event's openness.

Compassion, Appropriateness, and the Limits of Ethical Representation

Budhua's grief is not merely about the decline of his own body; it arises from the fear that four neglected lives will vanish. The focus of compassion therefore shifts from "an old man is dying" to "a community's memories and rights depend on a single elderly person." Its aesthetic basis is the recurrence of names and the dramatic sequence of four addresses. Yet an issue of aucitya remains unavoidable: entry into the water is described as exceptionally peaceful, beautiful, and devoid of fear. Such aesthetic organisation risks concealing the human dangers attached to a decision concerning death. The lack of substantial consideration of alternatives for life and collective preservation is a critical limitation. Sympathy for a character's suffering and belief that his final action is inevitable are separate judgements.

Table: States, Scenes, Evidence, and Outstanding Questions

State or scene	Kind of evidence	Narrative transformation	Unresolved question
Long time in the village	Narrator's summary	Seven generations and rebuilding of institutions	Budhuā's biological lifespan is unnatural
Safeguarding names	Conch and cord; repeated names	An elderly witness becomes the bearer of communal memory	Individual choice; incomplete written archive

State or scene	Kind of evidence	Narrative transformation	Unresolved question
Raghunāth's question	Direct dialogue between characters	The Vācaspati era returns to discussion	Actual number of years is not specified
Four addresses	Budhuā's direct speech	Unresolved injustices gather in personal recollection	Necessity of entering the water unproven
Disappearance	Interior vision; an "as if" image	Transformation of a human presence	Crocodile attack not directly witnessed
Search at dawn	A fisher finds the conch and cord	Memorial objects become public	No body or cause of death is found
Folklore of Burhba	People's account and symbolic numbers	Tradition of shadow, names, and witness-tree	Folk memory does not establish a material ghost

Event Sequence, Causal Chain, and What Remains Unresolved

At least seven changes of state can be distinguished: (a) transformation of the village and its institutions after many generations; (b) confirmation of Budhua's position as guardian of memory; (c) Raghunāth's question revealing the seemingly impossible age; (d) Budhua's decision to approach the water out of fear that memory will perish; (e) addresses to four dead or forgotten people and disappearance into the pond; (f) the fishermen's discovery of conch and rope and Vardhamāna's public memorial act; (g) the shaping of the Burhba ghost-story and the figure of "twelve hundred years" through folk tradition. This is a classification for research, not definitive machine-counted data. The social causal connection between (a) and (d) is intelligible, but the inference from (d) to (e)—that entering the water alone can preserve names—remains unproved. Material evidence of conch and rope and the perception of a shadow in folklore belong to different evidentiary categories. The future expansion towards Channa Gachhi is anticipation, not a directly enacted historical or botanical event.

The Work's Principal Achievement and Principal Weakness

The chapter's chief achievement is its incorporation of several distinct tragic events from the prehistory into the life of one long-enduring figure of memory. Within an unnatural folkloric timescale, concerns about social archives, caste, women's labour, and delayed justice remain alive. Each of the four addresses gives a specific ethical place to a name, while the conch, rope, peepal, and pond become recurring symbols. The narrator himself distinguishes folkloric time from historical chronology: a significant measure of authorial caution. The weaknesses include the unproved necessity of water burial, the absence of a directly seen crocodile, insufficient consideration of alternative social records, and ambiguities in some environmental descriptions of the river and pond. The exceptionally beautiful account of disappearance provides little space for the character's

actual fear or a community's response. Without acknowledging these limits, a fair assessment of the work is impossible.

Narrative Bridge to Chapter −89 and Final Judgement

The ending links Burhba's shadow to the future of Channa Gachhi, constructing a long bridge between prehistory, folklore, and the principal narrative. The next chapter, "The First Night, the First Flood," must be examined to discover how the new presence of memory acts during a public crisis; its specific actions must not be decided by conjecture before the next text is read. The independent judgement on "Budhua's Water Burial" is that the chapter does not simply pronounce death a victory. It tells the story of a tragic technique of remembering, born of archival failure. The certain end of the body and the material existence of a ghost are not established on the same evidentiary level, but the village's continuing circulation of Burhba's story is a socially attested event in the narrative. Justice may remain unfinished; calling a name preserves the knowledge that it remains so.

Chapter −90: Register of Evidence Verified Against the Original Text

Proverbial assertion — "The crocodile took the body and left the name."

Institutional time — "The assembly building had fallen twice and been rebuilt twice."

Generation of scholarly inheritance — "Seventh-generation successor."

Restoration of the witness-character — "And Budhua was still alive."

New folkloric name — "Burhba."

Repeated names — "Hulāsā's"; "Jīvantī's"; "Sukhdev's"; "Ratnā's."

Seasonal image — "Cold as ice."

The disciple's question — "Burhba, how old are you?"

Historical astonishment — "Vācaspati Miśra?"

Body and memory — "Not in my body, but in my memory."

Memory's burden — "Memory becomes a burden."

Hulāsā's unfinished speech — "I..."

Limits of representation — "This was not my right."

Jīvantī's unfinished words — "To bear witness to a book is also..."

The witness's promise — "I will be a witness, Jīvantī."

Sukhdev's institutional legacy — "The Sukhdev Rule."

Memory of Ratnā′s labour — “Not with ink, but with memory.”

Careful personification of the peepal — “It seemed to lean towards him.”

Vow and lifespan — “This itself breaks the limits of age.”

Absence of a body — “Neither body, nor footprints, nor any sign of struggle.”

Vardhamāna′s mourning — “Budhua has not died.”

Formula of folk tradition — “People began to say.”

Traditional number — “Twelve hundred years.”

Song and the persistence of names — “A name carried by the village cannot be lost in any water burial.”

Paratextual difference in chronology — “Four or five hundred years later.”

Explanation of folkloric time — “Memorably remote antiquity.”

Critical Section 12 | Original Chapter −89 — The First Night, the First Flood

Textual Basis, Chapter Boundaries, and the Critical Question

"The First Night, the First Flood" is the twelfth chapter of the prehistory. The contents of the complete original novel place its beginning on page 152 and the beginning of Chapter −88, "The Accusation of Witchcraft," on page 158. The cited page range in the original edition is therefore 152–157. This range is not a complete measure of event density; the causes, alternatives, and consequences of the principal events must be examined separately. After the original story, an explanatory section entitled "A Note on the Embankment of Garh Narikel and the Flood Traditions of Mithila" appears. Rather than treating it as historical proof of narrative events, it should be read as an interpretation supplied within the text. This chapter asks: if water is an autonomous power of nature, whose decisions determine the social distribution of destruction? And if the witness is a supernatural consciousness, where do the limits of rescue begin?

From Water Burial to the First Trial: A Knot in the Sequence of Causes

In Chapter −90 Budhua disappears bodily and becomes transformed into Burhba in the community's folklore. The bracketed introduction to the new chapter expressly marks the passage of one year and describes the first flood as Burhba's first test. The unresolved question from the preceding chapter—whether protecting names is sufficient or protecting living people is also required—therefore becomes an immediate conflict within a scene. The symbols of the prehistory—philosophical disputation, manuscripts, the witness-tree, and water burial—now confront an urgent duty to act. This succession is more than a linking of episodes; it is a test of an ethical rule already established. But by calling the event a "test" in advance, the introductory note partially directs the reader's evaluation and somewhat narrows the scope for experiencing the result independently.

The Expansion of Night and the Compression of Time

The night's events proceed in sequence: wind, then lightning, then torrential rain, the roar of the Kamla-Balan, Gaurī's dream, her awakening, the warning, the collapse of the embankment, flight, and the accounting of loss at dawn. Many changes of state take place in one night, while Burhba's year of existence is merely background. There is no static interval of joy or reassurance; the very short time available for reactions accelerates the narrative. A sentence such as "But there was very little time" contracts experienced duration and heightens uncertainty. At dawn and at

noon, the pace slackens again, allowing readers to comprehend the grief of seven deaths and the meaning of the new rule. In Gérard Genette's terms, the distinction among scene, summary, and pause needs to be recognised; a count of rapid action verbs alone is insufficient.

The River's Voice and the Spatial Organisation of the Leatherworkers' Quarter

At the beginning, the waters of the Kamla-Balan become an active and uncertain force. Yet the river alone does not create the inequality of the impact. The southern edge of the village, the low-lying ground, the leatherworkers' settlement, and a temporary earthen embankment form a single geography of vulnerability. The detail that maintenance had depended only on soil left over from the cultivators suggests an absence of collective planning and equal protection. The greater exposure of the Dalit settlement is not a natural divine punishment; it arises from the use of land, priorities in construction, and social power relations. This is the central environmental-narratological achievement of the chapter: water generates the event, but structural inequality alters the distribution of its harm. Natural crisis and social injustice are different causal levels, not synonyms.

Narrator, Shifting Focalisation, and the Limits of Knowledge

A third-person external narrator presents the story, but experience travels from Burhba's inward fear to Gaurī's dream, the grandmother's ability to hear, and the settlement's collective flight. The narrator knows the sensations of Burhba's altered existence and also relates the sound of a bell arising in Gaurī's consciousness. Despite this broad access, Burhba himself does not know why Gaurī possesses her peculiar ability. Ignorance within the character is maintained even under extensive narrative knowledge, and this sustains the mystery. What only Gaurī experiences and what the narrator reports independently have different evidentiary standings. Critical reading should not merge these voices into a single objective testimony, but should identify the levels of narrative reliability.

Burhba's New Existence: Extensive Perception, Limited Power

Burhba senses the rising water through his roots, body, and conch, but when he tries to knock at a door, his hand slides across its wood. This contradiction is not a cheap multiplication of supernatural powers: perception is extensive while the means of communication are weak. A witness cannot warn society of an impending emergency. The scene exposes a real crisis in the ethics of testimony within the story. His question—"If a witness cannot save…"—tests his earlier vow. Yet later Burhba briefly redirects the water's course; the rules governing this new

capacity have not previously been clearly established. Magical narrative does not require a full scientific explanation, but the consistency of selective powers and failures still warrants examination.

Introducing Gaurī: Generations, Knowledge, and Unequal Rights of Inheritance

Seven-year-old Gaurī, a fourth-generation descendant of Ratnā and Mālatī, sleeps beside her grandmother in the leatherworkers' settlement. The grandmother's herbal knowledge, said to have been learned from Ratnā, makes a female family tradition into intellectual inheritance. This detail does more than choose a character through whom a miracle may occur: the first warning comes from a community formerly kept at a distance from the doors of scholarly disputation. The villagers treat Gaurī's dream as a child's imagination; her grandmother pays attention to its obscure suggestion. Both explanations remain possible within the text. It would be inappropriate to treat the supernatural capacity as a biological property of caste or lineage. Through one particular fictional character, the novel underlines the ethical importance of marginalised traditions of knowledge.

The Words in the Dream and Three Links in the Transmission of Information

Burhba cannot awaken the village by an ordinary call. Only in Gaurī's dream is a signal repeated: "Wake up. Wake up. Wake up." The first link is a supernatural appeal; the second is Gaurī's awakening and her communication to her grandmother; the third is the grandmother opening the door and seeing and hearing the water outside. The public warning spreads in earnest only when the grandmother calls the settlement on the basis of her own direct observation. The dream therefore has the status of personal experience for Gaurī, audible and visible evidence for the grandmother, and a collective announcement for the settlement. In an examination of pramāṇa informed by Navya-Nyāya, a sign received in a dream cannot automatically count as public perception or universal reliable testimony. Its practical value is supported retrospectively by the emergency that subsequently becomes evident.

Barking Dogs, the River's Roar, and an Environment of Information

Initially the grandmother takes Gaurī's dream for a nightmare, but changes her judgement when she hears the roar of water and the continual barking of dogs outside. Nonhuman sound becomes a necessary part of the warning. Environmental cognition in the story does not rest exclusively upon human sight: animal behaviour, the voice of the wind, and the gleam of water become signs of danger before it arrives. Yet the suggestion

that the dogs were "themselves seeing something" is an image offered by the narrator, not an established case of animal prediction. No single cause of the barking is conclusively provided. This caution preserves the literary role of nonhuman activity without inventing scientific certainty about the natural events.

The Breaking of the Embankment: The Actual Centre of Event Density

The failure of the embankment is the decisive external event. Its prior condition is an unsafe earthen barrier; the disruption is the force of the Kamla-Balan; the immediate result is flooding of the lower settlement; and the available choice is to abandon homes and flee towards higher ground. These four stages constitute the principal causal chain. Water rising from ankle height to knee height makes the shortage of time a bodily experience. The pace takes the reader directly into the emergency, even though water levels, duration of rainfall, and actual distances are not measured. In calculating event density, the critic must not treat multiple descriptions of one failed embankment as separate events; warning, flight, obstruction, and death are distinct changes of state.

The Cremation-Ground Mound: A Life-Saving Reversal of an Inauspicious Place

Gaurī's family reaches the high mound where an old cremation ground stands, a place usually avoided by villagers as inauspicious. This is an ethical rereading of geography. A forbidden place associated with death becomes a refuge that saves life; religious folk belief and topographical safety clash. The height of the mound offers a practical reason for escaping the water, although Burhba's momentary redirection of the current and the family's timing also operate within the story. The cremation ground is not merely a lesson against superstition: cultural symbols of life and death reverse themselves and acquire new meaning through human usefulness. The change of place is a concrete dramatic turn in the narrative's chronotope.

Rescuing One Family: The Ethical Tension of Collective Loss

Feeling Gaurī's fear, Burhba turns the water aside for an instant, enabling her family to reach the mound. The next line immediately recalls that the rest of the settlement was not equally fortunate. Supernatural rescue is therefore not omnipotent justice, but partial intervention. This limitation is ethically productive because a miracle does not erase social catastrophe. Yet the question remains: what rule of the fictional world accounts for Burhba's special responsiveness to Gaurī's family and the failure to save others, including Subhāgī? His own lack of understanding is one possible answer, but it does not provide adequate causal clarity. The indeterminacy

may be effective for aesthetic experience while remaining incomplete as an explanation.

Subhāgī's Death: Scene, Indirect Testimony, and Generational Loss

The old home of Somar and Ratnā is swept away. Family members attempt to carry the aged and disabled Subhāgī to safety, but the current takes her from them. Her reported last question—"Did Gaurī survive?"—binds the event to a name. The narrator, however, introduces the words as something "the villagers later continued to say." They are not a directly recorded final utterance, but part of a subsequent communal account. Their poignancy is undeniable; their evidentiary status must nevertheless be specified. Gaurī survives and Subhāgī dies: the story depicts generational continuity and rupture at once. The elder's bodily vulnerability also exposes the different risks of disaster; the intersection of caste, age, and disability emerges from the stated circumstances.

Seven Dead, Six Unnamed: Counting and the Power of the Archive

The narrative reports seven deaths, but the names of six people besides Subhāgī are not properly entered in the official record. The royal official first counts losses of grain and cattle in the Brahmin settlement. In this single scene the novel distinguishes a count of the dead from justice towards their names. A total of seven does not encompass the whole of grief; the erasure of six names generates an urgent need for communal remembrance. The state register becomes a document structured by power. Yet this one fictional scene cannot establish the intentions of every official or the behaviour of an entire historical administrative system. Videha's method of parallel history would ask how family testimony, traces of labour, and communal memory might yield histories distinct from official entries.

Burhba's Weeping and the Peepal Leaves: A Vehicle for Karuṇa-rasa

At dawn Burhba weeps for the first time, but has neither human tears nor an audible human voice. The peepal leaves appear wetter than dew "as though" affected by the grief. Through this comparison, nature becomes a visible medium of mourning without the narrator establishing that the tree literally secretes tears. The dead Subhāgī and the other unnamed people are the supporting objects of karuṇa-rasa, and Burhba's inability to help intensifies the sorrow as a bodily response. The strength of the image is its indirectness: where weeping cannot be heard, the tree becomes the visual language of grief. If the tree were read entirely as a giver of human emotion, however, its independent ecological existence might shrink into mere symbolism. Both readings remain possible.

Gaurī and Burhba in Dialogue: Confessing the Limits of Partial Success

At noon Gaurī brings her grandmother's grief to the peepal. Burhba responds, "I could save only some." This is the most significant ethical statement of his new existence. He does not take satisfaction in saving Gaurī, but remembers his earlier inability to help Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sukhdev. The chain of memory thus becomes a source of ethical instruction rather than simply a list of names. The worth of lives saved and the grief of those not saved stand together. Still, extended moral exposition after the climax of compassion leaves the reader somewhat less room to judge independently. The story gives this lesson dramatic form through Gaurī's questioning, but does not elicit fully developed disagreement.

The Figure of the Half-Ghost: A New Grammar of Witnessing

Burhba does not understand Gaurī's ability to hear him. He speculates —"perhaps"—that a person ready to become a witness turns into a slender thread between two worlds. This is not an objective law of ghostly existence but the character's tentative self-interpretation. "Half-ghost" can also serve as a social metaphor: one who hears unheard voices stands on the boundary between living society and vanished memory. The making of a new saying, from private conversation into a domestic warning, shows how words become popular understanding independently of ritual. To transform a conjecture into certain direct knowledge would contradict the epistemic caution associated with Navya-Nyāya. The preservation of uncertainty is an artistic gain.

The Changing Village Name: Invented Etymology and Folk Archive

The narrative says that after the flood an embankment was built of fired bricks and stone, and "Narikel-Ghat" gradually came to be called "Garh Narikel." "Garh" was attached to the memory of the new barrier. The note following the original chapter expressly calls this an imagined etymology, not evidence of the place-name's actual historical origin. Readers may interpret the geographical name as an inscription of communal responsibility. Changing the name does not bring back the seven dead, but places a trace of the calamity in public speech. The further question remains whether, over time, a beautiful moral account of the name might itself efface the details of actual neglect.

New Priorities for the Embankment: Policy Change and Contradiction

After the disaster, the portion protecting the leatherworkers' settlement is built first and made strongest. The story translates a natural disaster into a

social decision: the formerly neglected periphery is now accorded priority for safety. This is a genuine transformation in the situation—physical construction and communal policy—and a more concrete outcome than the partial miracle. Yet the entire decision is compressed into one paragraph. The sources of funds, division of labour, opposing interests, maintenance, and effectiveness in future floods are not tested in scenes. The assessment is consequently double: giving policy justice a material form is an achievement, whereas the rapid closure of a difficult collective process is a structural simplification. The twenty-year interval of the next chapter will offer a partial test of the policy's survival.

Collective Song and the Meaning Made After Disaster

The closing song chooses the language of communal reconstruction after flood destruction. Lines such as "The first flood took our homes" and "Those who survived that night" turn a specific scene into recurring folk memory. Its rhythm shifts the narrative voice from unbearable grief towards collective endurance. This is an artistic expression of popular feeling and survival. Yet the rapid arrival of optimism after seven deaths and six lost names can feel emotionally accelerated. The transition from compassion to encouragement makes the intention clear while retaining a substantial tension between reassurance and continuing exposure to harm. The song should be understood as an expression of retrospective communal meaning, not a complete resolution of events.

Separate Classification of Event, Cause, and Consequence

The central event is a destructive flood, but several independent decisions and transformations surround it: the swelling river; Burhba's unsuccessful warning; Gaurī's dream; the grandmother's observation outside; the settlement's flight; the failure of the embankment; rescue of Gaurī's family; seven deaths including Subhāgī; inadequate registration of losses; Burhba's dialogue with Gaurī; reconstruction of the embankment; and the change of place-name. Flattening these into one list would erase causal order and responsibility. The dream, for example, does not cause the embankment to fail. Its weakness is an antecedent social condition; rising water is the proximate physical cause; the time available for warning affects the result of escape. The miraculous redirection of the water is a cause within the fictional world, not an independently verified scientific fact about river flow. Such distinctions are crucial in evaluating event density.

The Politics of Focalisation: Who Speaks and Who Does Not?

The reader hears Gaurī, her grandmother, and Burhba. Subhāgī's last words are mediated through a community report; the other six dead have no independently voiced utterances. This silence is both a subject of the

work and one of its limitations. The story exposes archival exclusion but cannot develop the six lives independently within its text. At the point where society fails to register their names, the narrator does not recover them either, producing an ethical contradiction in representation. Before declaring this a final failure, one must test whether the names recur in subsequent chapters. Yet within the limits of this chapter, Gaurī's family enjoys more narrative space than the six unknown dead.

Stylistic Incongruity, Over-Explanation, and Scenic Coherence

The opening flood sequence describes a splitting sky, torrential rain, barking dogs, and the river's roar. Yet at the moment of warning the grandmother's call is said to be audible because "the night was so quiet." There is a clear verbal incongruity: noisy turbulence and total stillness are attributed to the same temporal setting without a clarifying indication that "quiet" means the silence of sleeping villagers or distracted human attention. Similarly, the rules governing Burhba's bodilessness and brief power to turn water remain unclear even to him; this unnatural convention invites tests of narrative consistency. The new etymology and rapid repair of the embankment also supply a near-epilogue resolution within a brief interval. Naming these weaknesses does not diminish the work's compassion or its attention to marginalised people; it judges achievement and craft together.

Navya-Nyāya, Indian Poetics, and a Combined Verdict

In the language of Navya-Nyāya, the proposition to be tested is not simply "the village flooded" but "unequal protection increases social risk." The proposed reason is a weak earthen embankment beside a neglected low-lying settlement. One fictional case does not establish a universal pervasion across every place. The intensity of rainfall, terrain, maintenance capacity, and timely warning are consequential limiting conditions. Gaurī's dream is private experience; the grandmother's observation offers a more publicly checkable basis for social decision. At the level of Indian poetics, karuṇa-rasa, the suggested grief of the peepal leaves, the oblique reversal of the cremation ground, and the appropriateness of prioritising the neglected settlement's security are important. The chapter's foremost accomplishment is not supernatural rescue but exposure of the social inequality of disaster and its transformation into the construction of a better embankment. Its limitations are rapid moral closure, the silence of six dead, and incomplete rules for the redirection of the flood. It is therefore a powerful, though not unassailable, juncture at which the previous narrative of memory becomes a narrative of social action.

Bridge to Chapter –88 and Final Critical Position

After the first flood, the new embankment and Gaurī's distinctive ability to witness provide the material for future social conflict. The title of Chapter –88, "The Accusation of Witchcraft," suggests that recognition of a woman's unusual knowledge is not guaranteed. Its events must not, however, be treated as already having occurred here. In this chapter Gaurī does not know the origin of her dream, and Burhba likewise admits his limitations. Preserving their uncertainty, the initial conclusion is that the prehistory has now entered the present crisis of marginalised communities, water security, and archival rights. Private grief becomes collective speech, material construction, and a change in social practice. But memory will be complete only when the seven dead are named and responsibility for their losses is addressed. That question must be followed through subsequent sections with textual evidence.

Chapter –89: Table of Event, Evidence, and Cause

State or event	Form of textual evidence	Cause and consequence	Distinct evidentiary limit
Rising Kamala-Balan	Weather description and Burhba's perception	Proximate natural cause of the water crisis	No external measurement of water levels
Weak embankment of the leatherworkers' quarter	Narrator's description of society and terrain	The lower settlement faces disproportionate danger	Long-term maintenance and resource allocation are compressed
Burhba loses his voice	Supernatural focalisation	Warning fails at a physical door	Rules of his altered existence uncertain
Gaurī's dream and grandmother's observation	Private experience followed by shared auditory and visual signs	Warning and flight begin	The dream is not a public perception
Failure of the embankment	External scene; water rising from ankle to knee	Houses are washed away; time to flee contracts	Concrete consequence of socially unequal risk
Cremation-ground mound and deflection of water	Survival of Gaurī's family; supernatural simile	One family survives	Not a collective rescue; mechanism unexplained
Seven deaths, including Subhāgī	Narrative report; last words reported by others	Displacement and family grief	Six dead unnamed; quoted words indirect
Damage counted by a royal official	Narrator's institutional commentary	Records structured by class and caste	No independent proof of the broad historical assertion
New masonry embankment	Summarising epilogue by the narrator	Protection of the marginal settlement is prioritised	Construction process and long-term durability omitted
The name Garh Narikel	Post-narrative explanation	A place-name marks collective memory	Fictional etymology, not objective history

The table keeps supernatural descriptions, enacted scenes, reported accounts, and post-narrative interpretation in separate evidentiary

categories. Its rows are a preliminary analytic list of states and events, not definitive statistical event-density data.

Chapter −89: Register of Evidence Verified Against the Original Text

Opening proverb — “The first flood took our homes.” Original Part 0, Chapter −89.

Bracketed chronology — “Exactly one year after Budhua's water burial.”

Beginning of the night — “Half the night had passed.”

Opening image of disaster — “The sky split open.”

Burhba's experience of danger — “The Kamla-Balan was about to break its bounds.”

Unsafe embankment — “Only a few heaps of earth.”

Burhba's inability — “His hand could no longer touch the door.”

Ethical self-questioning — “If a witness cannot save…”

Gaurī's genealogy — “The fourth generation of Ratnā and Mālatī's lineage.”

Dream warning — “Wake up. Wake up. Wake up.”

First notice of danger — “Water is coming.”

Grandmother's auditory evidence — “The sound of roaring water.”

Contraction of narrative time — “But there was very little time.”

Failure of the embankment — “Collapsed like a castle of sand.”

Place of rescue — “A high mound.”

Figure of supernatural help — “Some invisible hand.”

Decisive loss — “Subhāgī was left behind.”

Reported last words — “Did Gaurī survive?”

Unequal archival naming — “They were from the leatherworkers' quarter.”

Burhba's bodiless grief — “Neither tears nor voice.”

Admission of limited success — “I could save only some.”

Tentative self-explanation — “Perhaps the human being who is ready to bear witness…”

Construction of the new barrier — “Of fired bricks and stone.”

Change in priority — "The part towards the leatherworkers' quarter first of all."

Note following the chapter — "An invented etymology." This is not a historical fact.

Critical Section 13 | Original Chapter −88 — The Accusation of Witchcraft

The Original Text, Chapter Boundary, and Purpose of the Examination

"The Accusation of Witchcraft" is the thirteenth independent chapter of the prehistory. The contents of the complete original novel place its beginning on page 158 and that of Chapter −87, "At the Gate of the Settlement," on page 164; the referenced printed range is therefore pages 158–163. This proportional indication is not an objective measure of narrative change, but only a preliminary linguistic marker. In the original, the opening saying, the principal story twenty years later, the closing women's song, and the special note entitled "Historical Relations between Witchcraft Accusations and Land Appropriation" are distinct textual forms. This criticism jointly examines the social workings of the accusation, the fallacious reasoning behind fabricated evidence, the incomplete beginnings of resistance, and the narrator's choices. The appendix-like note will not be treated as independent historical evidence.

The Omission of Twenty Years: A Night Becomes the Distance of a Generation

In the previous chapter seven-year-old Gaurī heard the warning of a flood. Here the narrator explicitly states that twenty years have passed. Gaurī is twenty-seven, the mother of two children, knowledgeable about medicinal plants, and recognised as a healer in the community. This arithmetic consistency supplies a stable basis for the sequence. Yet the changes over twenty years—the permanent embankment, the spread of cultivation, and distant markets for drums and other crafts—are presented in summary rather than scene by scene. In Gérard Genette's analysis of duration, the compression of extensive story-time quickly introduces the new crisis, while leaving the detailed experience of labour, production, and embankment maintenance outside the reader's sight. The calamity of the preceding chapter returns here as a potential redistribution of property; the temporal ellipsis compresses the years following destruction.

Embankment, Settlement, and Prosperity: The Unexpected Political Consequences of Water Security

The new embankment does more than guard against natural danger. Betel leaves and vegetables thrive upon its raised ground, and the products of artisans reach more distant markets. The economic value of the leatherworkers' labour increases. The lack of security that had cost lives

during the first flood has been partially corrected, and this correction now gives rise to conflict over esteem and land rights. The causal sequence is important for environmental narratology: danger from the river → communal construction → opportunities for production → a reaction concerning status. A general statement that the settlement has become "prosperous" does not prove that income is equally distributed among its households; no household accounts are supplied. Nevertheless, the caste-and-class direction of the opposition is clear: improvements for others are perceived as losses by those accustomed to dominance. The politics of water security therefore touches both natural resources and social rights.

Pratāpsen: Hereditary Power and the Humiliation of Comparison

Pratāpsen Thakur is the grandson of Ugrasen Thakur. This genealogical identity anchors the chapter in the memory of earlier social oppression. His speech joins the actual decline of his own property to the increased prosperity of the leatherworkers' settlement, without supplying a causal accounting of either. The comparison immediately becomes a question of rank: who has the right to sell grain "on an equal footing with us"? More than economic competition, the demand for caste supremacy is audible in the question. The narrator directs interpretation through words denoting his anger and pride rather than leaving his motives entirely open. This makes the ethical shape of the conspiracy clear, but it offers little independent detail about his losses, debts, or obstacles to production. A potentially complex economic anxiety is presented as relatively simple moral villainy.

Yaśpati's Narrative Function: From Religious Authority to the Manufacture of Accusations

Paṇḍit Yaśpati is the ritual presiding officer of the village's new assembly building. His prestige serves in the story not to examine truth but to translate a charge into an apparently authoritative form. His proposed use of categories such as "impure" and "inauspicious" in connection with reconsideration of land rights reveals his relation to power. Particular caution is necessary: although Yaśpati speaks as though he were interpreting a rule governing redistribution of land, the novel gives no actual statutory section, date, jurisdiction, or independent enactment. His claim must therefore be read as a character's strategy within the fictional world, not as evidence of Indian law. The alliance between popular fear and institutional paperwork is his principal narrative function.

"Evidence Is Manufactured": An Ethical Inversion of the Word *Pramāṇa*

Yaśpati declares, "Evidence is made, Thakur Sahib; it is not asked for." This is the chapter's epistemological centre. In the initial philosophical debates, pramāṇa involved the search for a truthful basis of knowledge. Here "evidence" becomes an object deliberately produced to sustain an accusation. The word remains the same while social conduct reverses its meaning. In a Navya-Nyāya perspective, the validity of evidence does not depend on the desire of a partisan or the number of people in a crowd; it depends on a defined subject, observation, non-deviating reasoning, and the examination of opposition. Yaśpati's plan is to attach some actual incident of illness to the name of a person already designated as guilty. The offence here is not the illness itself but the seizure of power over its interpretation. This single utterance greatly sharpens the chapter's ethical force.

Gaurī's Healing Practice: Service of the Body and the Refusal of Knowledge

Gaurī's knowledge of medicinal plants has descended through Ratnā's female lineage. The narrator says she has experience of many sick people and childbirths in the village. Her usefulness is established through relations of care, yet her knowledge is not accorded secure recognition in the hierarchy of prestige. The observation that "knowledge was not in a book but in the hands" makes visible the opposition between the experienced labour of women and written, authorised scholarship. This does not automatically demonstrate that the experience yields medically valid conclusions: the novel contains no modern examination of therapeutic efficacy. Yet injustice in denying a person's right to knowledge solely because of the bearer's identity is established in the narrated world. Gaurī's vocation is therapeutic; the language of accusation is violent. This contrast generates the chapter's central pathos.

The Half-Ghost Image and Social Suspicion

Gaurī is called a "half-ghost," and she sometimes hears Burhba's voice. This develops a distinctive rule of the fictional world from the first flood; it is not an ordinary sociological fact. The narrator supplies the reader with the context for her experience, while Pratāpsen and Yaśpati turn the rumours about this invisible dialogue into a doctrine directed against the woman. Unnatural narrative and social violence intersect here. What is a special experience in the character's consciousness becomes raw material for a charge of "witchcraft" in the hands of power. Even if the truth of her supernatural experience has one status within the narrative, rival characters

can arbitrarily alter its social meaning. Criticism must maintain the distinction between the two levels.

The Reader Knows More: Dramatic Irony

The reader overhears Yaśpati and Pratāpsen plotting in a private meeting at the mansion before Gaurī knows anything of their plan. The narrator expressly says that Gaurī had no unusual dream that evening and knew nothing of the conspiracy. This distribution of information produces dramatic irony: readers understand that the accusation is false before its intended victim is even aware of it. Rather than a detective plot leading to revelation, the story produces tension through the inability to forestall an injustice. The third-person narrator knows both the secret political conversation and the woman's private ignorance. Focalisation therefore does not remain fixed upon Gaurī but moves between extensive knowledge and selected proximity. The advantage of this technique is tragic irony; its cost is a reduction in ordinary mystery.

Viśvanāth's Illness: Distinguishing Opportunity from Design

Yaśpati's plan requires an illness that can be exploited. Viśvanāth, Pratāpsen's six-year-old son, develops a high fever. The failure of treatment during the first two days, unconsciousness on the third, and serious condition on the fourth night mark the illness's progress through short temporal stages. The narrator does not determine its cause. For the conspirators the illness is the occasion they sought; the text, however, presents no event in which either Yaśpati or Gaurī causes it. This distinction is essential to understanding the faulty reasoning behind the eventual charge. The illness is an independent and apparently contingent disturbance in the plot; the conspirators' use of it is a deliberate decision. To treat the onset of illness itself as a planned offence would contradict the original.

Kamalā Devī's Disobedience: Limited but Genuine Self-Determination

Viśvanāth's mother, Kamalā Devī, wants Gaurī to be summoned, but Pratāpsen forbids this on caste grounds. As the child's condition worsens, Kamalā Devī defies her husband and sends a maidservant to fetch Gaurī. This decision is a crucial moment of autonomous female action within the story. Kamalā Devī makes no political speech and does not argue in the public assembly, but she breaks a rule of dominance to seek medical help. Without her cooperation and that of the maidservant, Gaurī could not have reached the patient. It would, however, exaggerate the significance of this maternal decision to treat it as a fully formed consciousness opposed to

caste; her later public position is absent from the text. This absence is critically relevant.

The Scene of Treatment: Adequacy of Cause and Limits of Knowledge

Gaurī remains beside Viśvanāth throughout the night. The text mentions cool compresses and a decoction of neem and cirāyatā. By morning the fever subsides, and the child recognises his mother. Within the fictional world, this sequence is presented as Gaurī's successful care, but no diagnosis, assessment of earlier treatments, account of the illness's natural duration, or independent medical test is provided. The specific causal effect of the herbs should therefore not be cited as a proven result of real-world medical science. Narratively, Gaurī's intervention and the child's improvement form a decisive change of state; ethically, the life-preserving service conflicts with the social prejudices of the beneficiary family. Treatment and outcome are joined within the narrated sequence, without establishing an exceptionless universal inference.

Pratāpsen's Sense of Humiliation: Patriarchal Authority Against a Son's Life

Pratāpsen's son recovers, yet his first substantial response upon seeing Gaurī is anger. He is not responding to failed treatment but to the breaking of his order and a leatherworking woman's entry into his house. This contradiction exposes the ethical hierarchy of his priorities: even his son's health is subordinated to the rule of dominance. The narrator explicitly interprets his wounded pride, guiding the reader's moral judgement. Such interpretative insistence, however, leaves less room to experience the character's inner contradictions through dialogue and behaviour alone. The effect is forceful while psychological complexity remains limited. Narrative distance narrows as the narrator becomes the authoritative interpreter of guilt.

The Fallacy that Turns the Healer into the Cause of Disease

Yaśpati reverses the question: if the fever ended after this woman's treatment, perhaps she had caused it in the first place. This is an invalid inference, taking a later outcome as culpable evidence of an earlier cause. The subject (pakṣa) is Gaurī; the property alleged (sādhya) is her responsibility for producing the illness; and the purported reason (hetu) is the child's improvement after her treatment. The reason is not inseparably connected with the conclusion: not every person who treats a disease caused it, and not everyone who causes disease is a healer. The proposed reason is inconclusive (anaikāntika), while the social assumption concerning "witchcraft" intrudes to assign the outcome an illegitimate

meaning. Independent illness, the failure of earlier treatment, Gaurī's service, and natural changes are disregarded as alternatives. A Navya-Nyāya-oriented critique is effective here, although the narrative's use of "evidence" should not be presented as a verbatim formulation from Gaṅgeśa's original treatise.

From Slander to Public Accusation: Institutional Acceleration

A plan made privately becomes a public announcement in an emergency assembly. Yaśpati says he has "gathered evidence," but no witness, diagnosis, causal examination, or opportunity for Gaurī to answer is shown. The emergency meeting accelerates the accusation: instead of an inquiry, the crowd hears language of danger and ritual purification. This is an independent turn in the event sequence—an allegation becomes an official public accusation. The purported land regulation remains a character's claim, not verified law. The actual narrated result so far is public pressure, not a completed expulsion from the land; to assert that the settlement has already been evicted would bring a future event into the present chapter's chronology.

Punishment "Pending Investigation": The Difference Between Procedure and Justice

Yaśpati announces that until an investigation is completed, Gaurī should be excluded from religious activities and the entire leatherworkers' settlement barred from land near the embankment. Rights are to be restricted before facts are established. This is an ethical inversion of procedure: investigation should be a means of hearing an individual and her community, but its name becomes an instrument of preliminary punishment. The charge concerns one person while the restriction falls upon the entire settlement; this disproportion exposes the social purpose of the measure. In the terms of Navya-Nyāya delimitation, Gaurī's alleged behaviour and the collective land rights of the leatherworkers are distinct loci. An unproved allegation concerning the first cannot automatically extinguish the second. The novel exposes the moral flaw but does not supply an extensive account of legal jurisdiction or the mechanisms of appeal.

Silence in the Assembly: Between Gratitude and Fear

Some present in the assembly have children whom Gaurī previously saved. Memories of gratitude draw them towards objection, but Yaśpati's religious authority and Pratāpsen's influence suppress dissent. It would therefore be inaccurate to read the scene simply as "the village unanimously opposes Gaurī." The original records some resistance. Still, these opponents receive neither names nor fully developed arguments; possibilities of multiple

voices are compressed into narrative summary. Bakhtin's concept of polyphony should not be applied mechanically: several social positions are mentioned, but they are not all developed as autonomous worlds of thought. Silence is an effect of fear, not proof of agreement.

Gaurī at Home: Breastfeeding and the Violence of a Name Imposed Elsewhere

While the village authorities announce restrictions in the assembly building, Gaurī is at home breastfeeding her daughter. This simultaneity is especially effective. Public authority determines the guilt of someone who is absent, while the supposed culprit is engaged in the intimate work of sustaining her child's life. The violence of the charge threatens not an abstract individual but an existence made of motherhood, care, labour, and relationships. Breastfeeding can evoke karuṇa-rasa, yet Gaurī must not be reduced to the identity of a mother: she is also an experienced healer, a bearer of knowledge, and a person capable of independent decisions. The scene's achievement is bodily immediacy; its limitation is the absence of Gaurī's direct voice in the accusatory assembly.

Phulesarī: Messenger and an Enduring Thread of Women's Organisation

Phulesarī runs to Gaurī and tells her of the emergency assembly's accusation and proposed eviction. The narrator identifies her as a leading participant in the discreet evening circle of women associated with Ratnā's tradition. This links the female knowledge-community of Chapter –91 to a possible basis for present political resistance. Phulesarī is not merely Gaurī's friend; she is an alternative conduit for information about institutional decisions. News hostile to the assembly moves not through an official report but through women's social networks. Yet the organisation of the circle, its actual means of resistance, and the independent roles of Phulesarī's collaborators do not receive extensive depiction here. The possibility belongs to subsequent chapters; the critic cannot construct its complete history by inference at this point.

Gaurī's Question to Herself: Unequal Ethical Meanings of Gratitude

After hearing Phulesarī, Gaurī asks whether saving Viśvanāth was a mistake, or whether the mistake was to have been born in the leatherworkers' quarter. The force of the question lies in the ethical residue: why is the person who provides care treated as guilty? The narrator brings Ratnā, Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sukhdev into Gaurī's recollection. A personal accusation is thereby connected to a sequence of social humiliations across generations. The pattern of recollection joins the prehistory's separate crises in one ethical constellation, but their

circumstances are not identical. Jīvantī's disappearance in water, Sukhdev's death amid judicial delay, and the accusation against Gaurī must not be flattened into the same incident of oppression. A method of parallel history preserves both similarity and difference.

Running Towards Burhba: Uncertain Faith in Supernatural Aid

Gaurī leaves her child in Phulesarī's care and decides to go to the peepal. She wishes to speak to Burhba but also fears that he may again be powerless. His partial rescue during the first flood and the deaths of seven people remain implicitly active. This uncertainty complicates her character. Gaurī hears a supernatural voice but does not believe unconditionally in its omnipotence. Whether she reaches the peepal or receives an answer from Burhba is not shown in this chapter. To write the anticipated dialogue as a completed event would be unsupported. The narrative question remains open.

The Movement of Torches and an Open Ending: The Visible Rhythm of Fear

The chapter closes with the stilling of the wind and a moving light of torches from the direction of the assembly building. People carrying torches advance towards the leatherworkers' quarter. This is a sign of imminent attack, not an already completed act of arson. Narrative duration contracts into an evening moment and creates a crafted pause. The reader knows whom the conspirators have targeted, and Gaurī now has warning, but the community's response remains undecided. The ending makes a causal connection with Chapter –87, "At the Gate of the Settlement." Before reading it, the crowd's acts, the actual consequences of violence, and any intervention by Burhba must not be supplied as facts. Uncertainty keeps the ethical crisis alive.

Women's Song and Opening Saying: The Protection of Names and a Foreordained Moral Answer

The chapter's opening saying asserts the right to a name in opposition to the accusation. In the conclusion, some village women sing a song of resistance. "The crowd shouted, the torches burned, but no evidence was found": the argument becomes a communal utterance in folk melody. The song is not a formal essay on the ethics of testimony but a form of emotional public memory. In the terms of dhvani in Indian poetics, the opposition between preserving a name and burning a body deepens the work's meaning; emotional movements bordering on compassion and fury are present. Yet the song states the moral answer in advance—the charge is unjust. Where a reader might desire an independent examination

of evidence, the song's unequivocal conclusion can become somewhat directive. Both sides of its artistic function must be acknowledged.

The Included Historical Note: A Necessary Distinction

The closing "Special Note" makes a general claim about possible connections between accusations of witchcraft and land disputes, enmity, or the autonomy of women in several regions of India. This is a claim that can be examined historically, but the note within the novel does not provide independent records, surveys, judicial decisions, or research books for specific regions. This criticism therefore treats it as a social interpretation offered within the author's text, not as proven external history. The purpose of Videha's parallel-history method here is to raise questions about the victimised woman's speech, communal memory, and conflicts over land records. Regional archives and independent sources would be necessary for external historical generalisation. The boundary between the novel's ethical purpose and the historian's obligations of evidence is thereby preserved.

Event Density: The Actual Sequence of Independent Changes

The short chapter contains the following changes of situation: (a) economic improvement of the quarter after the flood; (b) Pratāpsen and Yaśpati planning an accusation; (c) Viśvanāth's illness; (d) Pratāpsen forbidding the healer's attendance; (e) Kamalā Devī secretly summoning Gaurī; (f) Gaurī's care and the child's recovery; (g) the conspiratorial reversal of the outcome; (h) the accusation in the assembly and a declaration restricting land rights; (i) Phulesarī delivering the news; (j) Gaurī setting out for the peepal; and (k) the advance of the torch-bearing crowd. This is an analytical sequence of states within the chapter, not a universally accepted published event count. Repeated sentences about a single treatment have not been counted as separate events to inflate density artificially. The initial figure of *55.9* per cent action-signalling paragraphs should be compared with this causal chain; the percentage alone does not measure social meaning.

Critical Judgement: Achievement, Contradiction, and the Bridge Ahead

The principal achievement of "The Accusation of Witchcraft" is its disclosure of the charge not as a spontaneous eruption of vague superstition but as a planned slander directed at land rights. Yaśpati's manufactured evidence, the conversion of Gaurī's healing into an accusation, and the proposed collective restriction "pending investigation" organise a conflict among knowledge, power, and justice. Gaurī's motherhood and healing practice, Phulesarī's communication, and Kamalā Devī's quiet

disobedience present distinct fields of female action. The artistic limitations are equally evident: Pratāpsen and Yaśpati are drawn as excessively one-dimensional antagonists; no independently verifiable legal provision is presented; the narrator repeatedly declares moral motives; auxiliary dissenters have little independent dialogue; and the historical generalisation about witchcraft requires more evidence than the internal note provides. Nonetheless, the chapter leaves its final question open: what living social decision will the protection of names now become? The answer must be sought in the actual text of Chapter –87, "At the Gate of the Settlement," not supplied by conjecture.

Chapter –88: Table of Events, Evidence, and Ethical Consequences

Event or situation	Evidence available in the text	Narrative consequence	Evidentiary limit of the conclusion
Twenty-year time gap	Parenthetical introduction; Gaurī is twenty-seven	Post-flood social scene opens	Changes across two decades occur in summary
Embankment and prosperity of the settlement	Narrator's accounts of fields and markets	Insecurity of the older ruling class intensifies	No ledgers for income or land distribution
Conspiracy in the mansion	Secret conversation of Pratāpsen and Yaśpati	Decision to seek an occasion for accusation	Alleged legal provision not independently verified
Viśvanāth's fever	Timed illness scene; initial treatment fails	Domestic crisis intensifies	Independent cause of illness unknown
Kamalā Devī's disobedience	She summons Gaurī through a maid	An opportunity for treatment arises	Later public views of mother and maid unreported
Gaurī's all-night care	Compresses, herbal decoction, child's improvement at dawn	Ethical force of life-preserving service	No external clinical test of the remedy's efficacy
False reversal of cause	Yaśpati's conspiratorial question	Treatment is turned into alleged "evidence" of guilt	Illness is not shown to have been caused by treatment
Emergency assembly	Yaśpati's public accusation; some objections	Secret plan becomes institutional pressure	No impartial hearing or record
Proposed prohibition pending inquiry	Demand to abandon religious work and embankment land	Attempt at collective punishment of Gaurī's settlement	Actual dispossession has not been shown
Phulesarī conveys the news	Direct information at Gaurī's house	The accused learns of the danger	Form of resistance remains undeveloped
Gaurī walks toward the peepal	Decision to speak to Burhba	Seeks supernatural or communal help	Burhba's answer does not occur in this chapter
Approaching torchlight	Final scene of the chapter	Open turning point before threatened violence	The crowd does not actually commit violence here
Women's song and historical note	Song is resistance within the text; note is a general assertion	The meaning of the right to one's name expands	Song is not an archive; note lacks external references

The table keeps the characters' allegations, events narrated directly, commentary beyond the story, and readerly inferences in distinct categories. Naming an event does not automatically establish its cause.

Chapter −88: Register of Evidence Verified Against the Original Text

Opening saying — "The one whom the village called a 'witch'…" Original Part ०, Chapter −88.

Chronological indication — "Twenty years after the flood."

Social and environmental change — "The new embankment, of fired bricks."

Gaurī's age — "Now twenty-seven years old."

Designation of an unnatural state — "Half-ghost."

Pratāpsen's wounded self-interest — "My property is diminishing year after year."

Yaśpati's alleged land-regulation category — "Impure."

Institutional language for constructing stigma — "Inauspicious."

The name imposed upon Gaurī — "Witch."

Conspiracy's epistemological formula — "Evidence is manufactured."

Yaśpati's strategy — "Fear travels faster than reasoning."

Onset of Viśvanāth's illness — "Suddenly fell into a high fever."

Pratāpsen's prohibition — "Shall I let a woman of the leatherworkers' settlement touch my son?"

Kamalā Devī's decision — "Against her husband's command."

Treatment described — "Applying cold compresses."

Narrative outcome — "The fever subsided."

Kamalā Devī's gratitude — "You saved my son's life."

Yaśpati's reversal of cause and result — "How does this prove…?"

False public claim of evidence — "I have gathered evidence."

Temporal condition for punishment — "Pending investigation."

Ambivalent assembly — "Torn between fear and gratitude."

Simultaneity of private life and public accusation — "Breastfeeding her daughter."

Gaurī's question about knowledge — "Knowledge was not in a book but in the hands."

Decision leading to the next chapter — "I must speak to Burhba."

Incomplete scene of the crowd — "Torches were moving slowly towards the leatherworkers' quarter."

Women's concluding song — "But there was no evidence anywhere."

Critical Section 14 | Original Chapter −87 — At the Gate of the Settlement

Textual Basis, Delimitation, and Critical Questions

“At the Gate of the Settlement” is the fourteenth independent chapter in the period of prehistory. The contents of the original combined trilogy place its opening on printed page 164 and the beginning of Chapter −86 on page 169. The relevant printed range is therefore 164–168. The percentage previously given is not a count of events; it is merely an initial indicator for examination. The principal chapter comprises an opening proverb, parenthetical contextual information, the crisis scene, a brief account of the following day's outcome, and a song. A separate authorial discussion entitled “Commentary on Chapters [−87]–88” follows it; that discussion must not be conflated with a character's speech or with actions taking place within the chapter. The central questions are these: how does a false accusation break down under collective testimony; what part does the miraculous play in relation to that social force; and how secure does justice remain after victory?

An Unbroken Connection with the Previous Chapter: The Torches Return

The final image of Chapter −88 left a torch-bearing crowd advancing towards the leatherworkers' settlement. The parenthetical introduction to the present chapter brings that crowd to the gate. The story-time continues almost without interruption. Rather than requiring the reader to absorb the background of a newly invented crisis, the narrative places the reader inside an existing emergency. The chapter break thus becomes a pause in expectation rather than an extension of the time in which the incident occurs. Yet the parenthetical introduction also announces in advance that the women have already decided not to remain silent. The reader therefore understands the likely direction of resistance from the beginning. This anticipation creates emotional expectancy while leaving relatively little space for an exploration of the surprise of the decision or the women's internal preparations.

The Roots of the Peepal: A Transformation of Place

Gaurī kneels at the roots of the peepal and calls upon Burhba. In preceding chapters this tree has been a place of names, testimony, and remembrance of the dead; now it becomes the centre of an appeal for help amid an immediate collective danger. Its chronotope differs from that of the crowd gathering at the gate: one is the long duration of memory carried through generations, the other the minute-by-minute imminence of violence.

Gaurī recalls the aid that arrived too late for Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sukhdev. That sequence of names does not collapse distinct deaths into a single event; instead, it makes unfinished justice the ground of present fear. The peepal is not the seat of an arbitrary miracle but a local archive of lived experience. This function allows the work to bring otherwise separate chapters of its prehistory together at one shared ethical and geographical point.

Gaurī's Prayer: Refusing to Assume an Omnipotent Rescuer

Gaurī's appeal—"Do not come too late for me today"—is not simply a request for rescue by a ghost. It is also a complaint grounded in the memory of previous deaths. She knows Burhba intimately through her unusual experience, but their relationship is not one of unconditional devotion. She recounts the history of delayed intervention: memory gives her the power to question even a supernatural being ethically. Such a perspective does not elevate Burhba into an unquestionable deity. Nevertheless, the narrative immediately makes his voice audible in answer to her prayer. The time available for dramatizing how Gaurī might prepare human alternatives in the crisis is correspondingly shortened. The author's choice converts her solitary appeal into a philosophical prelude to collective resistance. It is an effective transition, but the social preparation for that resistance remains insufficiently described.

The Limits of Burhba's Power: An Explicit Rule and a Subsequent Contradiction

Burhba states plainly: "My power cannot touch a body, nor can it extinguish a torch." Three forms of incapacity are expressed together: the inability to touch a body, act upon a torch, or stop the crowd. This seems to establish a rule for the fictional world in which the folkloric ghost is a witness to collective memory but not a physical saviour. Later, however, the torch in Yaśpati's hand goes out of its own accord, without wind or water, and Gaurī attributes this to Burhba. The passages are in unmistakable tension. Three possibilities remain: Burhba's initial declaration was incomplete; the extinguishing had some other, unknown cause; or the narrator breaks a previously established restriction in order to resolve the emergency. The text decisively establishes none of these explanations. To pronounce the miracle proof of Burhba's demonstrated power would therefore violate the very evidentiary discrimination demanded by the critical method.

"Many Mouths": From Solitary Evidence to Collective Speech

The heart of Burhba's answer is not bodily strength but the testimony of many people: truth needs "many mouths" from which to emerge. Previous

chapters exposed the vulnerability of a lone witness through Hulāsā's palm-leaf, Jīvantī's manuscript, and Sukhdev's silenced plea. Now numerous women's voices can come together. This is not simply the proposition that a large number of people utter the same thing; experiences from separate homes and families claim the right to public examination. The philosophical discourse of verbal testimony enters the social sphere here, but numbers alone cannot prove truth: a mob also has numbers. What matters is the subject of a statement, firsthand experience, its relation to the opposing claim, and the possibility of independent corroboration. The chapter dramatizes part of this difference without constructing a complete evidentiary examination.

The Gate: A Social Boundary and the Possibility of Violence

The torch-bearing crowd reaches the entrance of the leatherworkers' quarter. The gate is not merely an architectural boundary. It marks the division between orders imposed by the dominant strata and the independent lives of a working community. Pratāpsen comes in front, with Yaśpati behind him and fifty or sixty villagers advancing. Not everyone has the same motive: some genuinely fear what they have been told, while others are simply carried along by the crowd. This small distinction prevents the crowd from becoming a one-dimensional monster. Nevertheless, the narrative does not develop the individual participants' family and social positions, their degree of involvement in potential violence, or their doubts about the order's legitimacy. An anonymous crowd heightens the terror of the scene but restricts the analysis of responsibility.

Phulesarī's First Intervention: The Initial Right of Representation

Yaśpati summons Gaurī to come outside, but Phulesarī steps forward first. The solitary accused woman thereby gains a collective defence. Phulesarī recalls the ethical significance of treatment received: why punish the woman whose hands saved children? The narrator describes her voice as trembling but not breaking. Courage does not mean an absence of fear; it means deciding to speak in fear's presence. This is a convincing scene of independent social action. Still, a record of Gaurī's earlier care cannot, by itself, serve as final proof of innocence regarding every conceivable present allegation; past service and alleged present wrongdoing are logically distinct questions. The crucial fact is that the charge lacks independent evidence. Recalling the care she has given challenges prejudice rather than replacing the need to examine the charge.

Lamps and the Children's "Living Wall": Power and Ethical Risk

The women hold no weapons; they carry lamps and bring their children. This pairing turns the light that sustains life into a counter-image to the torches threatening violence. Their "living wall" places the community's own bodies before the power of the dominant class. But a unilinear celebration would be inadequate. Bringing children before fire and a hostile crowd also places vulnerable bodies in danger. The narrative does not depict disagreements among mothers about this risk or a practical plan to keep the children safe. The living wall is dramatically forceful, and its potential danger must be acknowledged at the same time. The symbol succeeds because actual bodies occupy the scene, but its ethical limit is the unanswered question of placing the least powerful in the front line of resistance.

Kamalā Devī's Unexpected Arrival: From Private Disobedience to Public Resistance

In Chapter –88 Kamalā Devī had summoned Gaurī to treat her son despite her husband's prohibition. Here she runs from the mansion to the gate, accompanied by the maid. An internal disagreement within the household now becomes public testimony. The maid's presence matters, since delivering the message and facilitating the journey were not accomplished by the mistress's decision alone. Yet the maid has no name, independent voice, or narrated decision. Kamalā Devī is barefoot, her clothes disordered and her breathing laboured: bodily urgency precedes political declaration. Her entrance therefore possesses the credibility of immediate intervention. She has not arrived to give a detached speech but to confront a visible threat.

"This Is a Man's Affair": A Direct Contest over Gendered Authority

Pratāpsen orders Kamalā Devī home: "This is a man's affair!" The sentence combines the domestic confinement of women, male control over public adjudication, and the elevation of family prestige above truth. Kamalā Devī counters, "This is not a man's affair; it is an affair of truth." Her ethical choice now becomes public defiance of the institutional order rather than a slogan alone. The narrator says that for the first time in her married life she stands directly before her husband. This formulation compresses the whole history of her marriage into a single dramatic instant. Rapid narration brings force to the turning point, but the gradual development of household politics remains unexplored.

Mother and Witness: Two Positions in One Person

Kamalā Devī speaks of Gaurī's contribution because Viśvanāth is alive. She is both the mother of the endangered child and a member of the dominant household. This dual position strengthens the social impact of her testimony: someone within Pratāpsen's own family challenges the public allegation. Nevertheless, the medical cause of the child's recovery is not fully determined. The source narrates Gaurī's care and the subsequent improvement, not a controlled medical test. Kamalā Devī's firsthand evidence concerns the prior condition of the child, Gaurī's attendance, the circumstances of treatment, and the change that followed. It exposes the inconsistency of Yaśpati's witchcraft accusation but does not independently establish a scientifically proven therapeutic miracle. Distinguishing the narrative's ethics from empirical verification preserves the force of both.

The Women's Separate Testimonies: Experience in the Plural

At Kamalā Devī's call, women from Brahmin, Kāyastha, and cultivating households separate themselves from the crowd. Three accounts concern difficult childbirth, a snakebite, and care for an elderly woman. The experiences are not interchangeable: one involves an emergency delivery, another an acute threat to health, and the third extended care without payment. Together they broaden Gaurī's role beyond that of a healer in a single instance, disclosing continuing labour, care, and relationships of trust. Although the women's social locations are distinguished, their different constraints, household prohibitions, caste prejudices, and risks are not individually dramatized. Their shared voice generates a justified emotional force, but it also risks merging distinct women's histories into a single refrain.

Independent Testimony or Repetition? The Test of Verbal Evidence

Three examples are quoted directly; the number of further voices is unspecified. The narrator imagines each voice removing a brick from the mountain of Yaśpati's lie. The metaphor is effective, but a philosophical question remains: have the witnesses' recollections influenced one another; are they addressing the same matter or different matters; and what are the limits of their direct knowledge? The three women attest to help Gaurī offered in the past. They do not directly refute a specifically demonstrated act of disease-making in the present, though the underlying charge is without proof. Verbal evidence cannot therefore be treated as a simple total of votes. Firsthand experience, the speaker's intentions, relevance to the disputed subject, and the lack of contrary evidence must all figure in appraisal. The novel strongly portrays communal moral truth without staging the entirety of formal evidentiary testing.

Yaśpati's Reply: The Fallacy of a Self-Insulating Accusation

Yaśpati calls the testimony "sentimentality" and modifies his accusation: a witch first behaves sweetly to entrap her victim. This renders the claim immune to any possible adverse evidence. If Gaurī cures an illness, it is deception; if she does not, it is malevolence. Either result is interpreted as proof of guilt. In the terms of evidentiary reasoning, the alleged ground has been insulated from refutation: no determinate and necessary connection between the purported sign and the offence has been established. It is a self-protecting accusation in which any result is read in favour of a conclusion chosen beforehand. Yaśpati's mastery of authoritative language now conflicts with the witnesses' accounts of experience. He is better understood as a conscious political producer of meaning than as merely a foolish believer in superstition.

The Unfinished Threat and the Dramatic Interruption

Yaśpati begins, "Whoever refuses to accept the truth, I shall ...," but cannot finish the sentence. The interruption allows the reader to perceive the threat while withholding the precise punishment he intended. Intention and completed action remain distinct. The broken sentence changes the dramatic rhythm: sustained social tension suddenly gives way to an extraordinary occurrence. Narrative time seems compressed into a single instant. The interruption of a coercive command momentarily reverses the balance of power, but the text does not fully develop how the women's testimony, the crowd's changing disposition, and Pratāpsen's hesitation might have stopped the threat without a miracle. An available realistic course of collective resistance is not explored in sufficient detail.

The Torch Goes Out by Itself: Wonder and Undetermined Causation

The torch in Yaśpati's hand goes out without a gust of wind or a drop of water. The scene immediately evokes adbhuta rasa, wonder, because the narrator excludes the ordinary physical causes. Yet "no ordinary cause has been described" does not entail "Burhba extinguished it." Gaurī offers that interpretation, but it remains the meaning attributed by a character within this fictional world. Earlier, Burhba had expressly declared himself unable to extinguish torches. The contradiction between the occurrence and his declared limitation cannot be disregarded. It is possible that the author has relaxed an internal rule in pursuit of a symbolic ethical triumph. The literary achievement lies in the dramatic economy of the image; the weakness lies in causal consistency and the danger of allowing a marvel to overshadow the work of human witnesses. Wonder does not cancel the demands of aucitya, or propriety.

Naming Burhba: Different Orders of Knowledge

When the torch goes out, Yaśpati asks what has happened; Gaurī answers by naming Burhba. Three distinct levels must be retained: the narrator describes the event, Gaurī explains its cause, and the crowd reacts. The narrator presents a physically unusual occurrence; Gaurī interprets it through intimate folkloric memory; the crowd reads it as an object of supernatural fear. These are not equivalent evidentiary positions. Their separation preserves the multiple interpretations of an unnatural narrative. Gaurī's insistence that Burhba does no harm accords with the established ethical disposition of the figure, but it does not establish precisely how a torch could have been affected. The reader can distinguish narrated occurrence from character belief, even though the emotional construction favours Gaurī's account.

Women's Testimony and the Miracle: Rival Causes of the Outcome

Uncertainty first appears among the crowd after Phulesarī's challenge; Kamalā Devī's public statement leaves them stunned; further testimonies loosen Yaśpati's command before he makes a final effort to regain control. Social efficacy is therefore present before the extraordinary incident. The extinguished torch becomes the immediate occasion for the crowd's retreat. Two possible grounds for ending the crisis stand beside one another: collective testimony and a supernatural sign. If women's testimony is decisive, it could have been more fully dramatized as the sufficient cause of the crowd's withdrawal. If the miracle is decisive, the autonomous work of evidence risks becoming secondary. The chapter retains both and leaves their causal relation unsettled. This double structure is at once a creative resource and a source of inconsistency.

Pratāpsen's Silence: Between Defeat and Revenge

Once Yaśpati's torch goes out, Pratāpsen abandons the punitive action and returns home without speaking. Gaurī sees humiliation rather than gratitude in his final glance, while the narrator raises the possibility of revenge. This prevents the error of equating defeat with ethical change. Pratāpsen does not publicly apologize even though his son has received care. But nothing is actually uttered by him in the moment, and the meaning of his inner disposition is inferred by Gaurī or the narrator. A future act of revenge cannot be represented as an accomplished event. The glance suggests intention without documenting a decision or deed. It is an effective forewarning of an unresolved conflict.

The Crowd Disperses: Incomplete Public Accountability

The villagers disperse, some ashamed, some relieved, some bewildered. These different reactions prevent every participant in the accusation from

being treated as identical. Yet the text does not identify who supported the charge, who changed after hearing the testimony, or who simply feared the extinguishing of the torch. Whether the next day's public record will reflect a lasting ethical change or only momentary alarm remains an open question. The crowd goes home without a narrated collective undertaking, discussion of restitution, or examination of its conduct. Immediate violence has been averted; the lasting disappearance of prejudice has not been demonstrated. The uncertainty adds realism, although individual responsibility is not developed in detail.

The Next Day's Re-entry of Land: An Abrupt Institutional Resolution

The statement that the land was "re-entered in the name of the leatherworkers' settlement at the following day's assembly" announces a direct political consequence. The preceding chapter described the plan to strip the community of its land rights through the accusation; the administrative record is now said to be restored. Land justice becomes more than the emotional victory of a departing crowd: it entails a community's recognized place in an official register. This is a significant narrative achievement. But the authority of the assembly, the original record, the evidence presented, the procedure, and the signatures are not shown. Nor was it wholly clear in Chapter –88 whether land had actually been taken away or whether a provisional restriction had only been announced. The result should be accepted as an outcome asserted within the story, not as evidence of the operation of historical Indian land law.

The Effect of Kamalā Devī's Intervention: A Possible Redistribution of Power

The narrator credits Kamalā Devī's forceful intervention with the re-entry of the land. Her moral act thus influences institutional decision-making beyond an immediate household disagreement. The limits of that shift also matter. As a woman of the dominant mansion, her testimony may receive weight that the voices of Gaurī, Phulesarī, and other women cannot independently command. Caste and gendered power intersect in this difference. An influential woman's intervention protects a Dalit community, yet the legitimacy of that community's rights remains in question if it ultimately depends on approval from the dominant house rather than the affected people's own testimony. The novel does not wholly resolve this tension.

Yaśpati's Removal and the Strategy of Silence

Yaśpati is removed from his position, but he does not leave the village. This is a precisely limited penalty: loss of office is not a criminal prosecution, and public silence is not the cessation of wrongdoing. Gaurī's sleeplessness

and her perception of coldness in his eyes suggest the possibility of another plot. The third-person narrator heightens her apprehension almost to the pitch of a future certainty, a technique of foreshadowing that requires evidentiary restraint. No completed new conspiracy, participants, date, or action is supplied here. Yaśpati's silence marks a strategic, unresolved danger. That residue makes the chapter's apparent triumph ethically complex.

Song, Proverb, and the Changing Meaning of Light

The opening proverb says, "A torch may come to the gate; the name within cannot burn." The closing song repeats and elaborates such lines, transforming private fear into collective utterance. The torch's flame is an instrument of violence; the women's lamps are signs of vigilant life; the peepal's memory figures continuity of names. In Indian poetics, the proximity of karuṇa, vīra, and adbhuta rasas, suggestive opposition, and symbolic recurrence shape the emotional design. But the song's line "The torch went out, yet the name kept burning" is potentially at odds with the opening assurance that the name cannot burn. If "burning" signifies the light of memory, the contrast can be interpreted constructively; if it means destruction, the lines point in opposing directions. The text does not settle the ambiguity, and editorial translation should not silently remove it. The song also turns risk into celebration quickly, potentially softening some of the unresolved ethical questions.

Temporal Duration, Focalization, and Event Density

The main sequence occurs over one night: Gaurī's appeal at the peepal; Burhba's reply; the crowd's arrival at the gate; Phulesarī's intervention; Kamalā Devī's arrival; several women's testimonies; Yaśpati's response; the torch's extinguishing; the crowd's dispersal; and Pratāpsen's departure. The assembly of the following day and the lingering apprehension are conveyed in summary. Treating three instances of testimony as three independent social outcomes would artificially inflate the event count. The narrator ranges widely among Gaurī's knowledge at the peepal, the crowd's diverse states of mind, Kamalā Devī's courage, and Pratāpsen's glance. Duration slows in the crisis, accelerates in the consequences, and becomes conjectural in the foreboding of the future.

The Post-Chapter Commentary and the Overall Critical Judgment

After the story, a discussion entitled "The Power of Collective Women's Testimony" connects the episode with the treatment of verbal evidence in Chapter –96, describing independent female testimony as a popular form of justice-oriented knowledge. This is an explanatory statement within the text, not a universally established rule of modern law. Independence,

relevance, and cross-examination of testimony vary with particular legal procedures. The chapter's achievement remains substantial: accounts of care unmask a political allegation; fearful women decide to speak publicly; unequal social positions are partially crossed; and a tangible outcome is stated in the re-entry of land. Its weaknesses are equally concrete: the conflict between Burhba's professed powerlessness and the extinguished torch; the possibility that the miracle diminishes the decisive status of women's evidence; the namelessness of the maid; the severely compressed land procedure; and the easy foreshadowing attached to the villains. The result is not "complete justice" but survival for one night, an unstable institutional victory, and the continuation of a long struggle. "At the Gate of the Settlement" strengthens the narrative's moral proposition that names are preserved through collective witness while leaving its causal artistry open to criticism.

Chapter –87: Event, Evidence, and Ethical Consequence

Event or claim	Evidence in the original text	Narrative consequence	Evidentiary limit
Gaurī prays at the peepal	Remembrance of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, and complaints about delay	Personal fear joins intergenerational testimony	Burhba has not yet provided physical help
Burhba declares his powers	Cannot touch bodies, extinguish a torch, or stop feet	Limits of the supernatural character stated	Internal tension with the later marvel
Torch-bearing crowd arrives	Pratāpsen, Yaśpati, and fifty or sixty villagers	Fear and public challenge at the doorway	Not all members of the crowd have the same motives
Phulesarī objects	Public recollection of the hands with which Gaurī saved a child	A personal accusation becomes a communal question	Prior service alone does not prove complete innocence
Living wall of women	Women stand at the gate with lamps and children	Collective tableau against violence	Text does not examine the actual risks to children
Kamalā Devī enters	Runs from the mansion with a maid and speaks publicly	Private dissent within the family becomes public	The maid's independent voice is absent
Multiple women's testimony	Accounts of childbirth, snakebite, and care in a final month	Gaurī's moral standing is restored	The testimonies receive no independent examination on stage
Yaśpati's self-insulating argument	Good deeds are recast as a witch's deception	Attempt to preserve an unsupported accusation	No valid invariable concomitance or direct evidence of causing illness
Unfinished threat	An imperative breaks off mid-sentence	Dramatic interruption of verbal violence	The intended punishment is never fully stated
Yaśpati's torch goes out by itself	Narrator reports no wind or water	The crowd is frightened; Yaśpati is stunned	Event is narrated, but Burhba's causation is disputed

Event or claim	Evidence in the original text	Narrative consequence	Evidentiary limit
Crowd disperses; Pratāpsen is silent	Shame, relief, confusion, and departure to mansion	Violence is stopped for that night	No proof of lasting change in prejudice
Land re-entered the following day	Narrator's concise account of the assembly's outcome	Claimed protection of communal registration	Procedures, records, and order are not supplied
Yaśpati removed from office	He loses his position but remains in the village	Immediate loss of power	No allegation process, prosecution, or repentance shown
Final communal song	Recurrent torch, names, wall, and fire	Public remembrance of resistance	Meaning of the line "the name kept burning" is ambiguous
Post-chapter commentary	Authorial analysis of the force of women's collective testimony	Bridge between epistemology and narrative	No independent historical or legal sources supplied

The table keeps distinct the acts narrated directly, interpretations supplied by characters, the narrator's compressed account of subsequent events, and unfulfilled possibilities. The occurrence of a miracle and the definite identification of its cause are not the same proposition.

Chapter −87: Verified Register of Evidence from the Original Text

Opening proverb — "A torch may come to the gate" — The initial statement of the threat.

Parenthetical chapter connection — "A torch-bearing crowd" — Link with Chapter −88.

Gaurī's appeal — "Do not come too late for me today" — Her complaint against delayed aid.

Burhba's declared limit — "My power cannot touch a body" — Restriction on action.

Burhba's declared limit — "Nor can it put out a torch" — Impossibility stated before the marvel.

Proposal of collective testimony — "Many mouths that have been silent for a long time."

Size of the crowd — "Fifty or sixty villagers."

The women's defence — "Carrying only lamps and their children."

Symbol of defence and risk — "A living wall."

Phulesarī's public question — "The woman whose hands saved all our children?"

Dissent from within the dominant household — "Kamalā Devī, Pratāpsen's own wife."

Pratāpsen's exclusion — “This is a man's affair!”

Kamalā Devī's reply — “This is not a man's affair; it is an affair of truth.”

Social range of testimony — “Some from the Brahmin quarter, some from the Kāyastha quarter.”

Testimony of childbirth — “Gaurī saved my daughter on the night of her birth.”

Testimony of treatment — “Gaurī cured my husband's snakebite.”

Unpaid care — “Without taking any payment.”

Yaśpati's rejection — “All these are matters of sentiment!”

Unfinished threat — “He could not finish the sentence.”

Extraordinary occurrence — “The torch went out by itself.”

Excluded ordinary causes — “Without a gust of wind, without a drop of water.”

Gaurī's explanation — “His name is Burhba.”

Different responses of the crowd — “Some ashamed, some feeling relieved.”

Pratāpsen's look — “There was the bitterness of humiliation.”

Land-related outcome — “Re-entered in the name of the leatherworkers' settlement.”

Incomplete punishment — “Yaśpati, even after being removed from his position.”

Warning of future conflict — “Silence and defeat are two different things.”

Concluding song — “The torch went out, yet the name kept burning.”

Critical Section 15 | Original Chapter −86 — The Crocodile of Time

Textual Basis, Chapter Boundaries, and Questions of the Study

"The Crocodile of Time" is the fifteenth independent chapter of the period of prehistory. In the contents of the original combined trilogy, its opening is assigned to printed page 169 and the opening of Chapter −85, "The Āmil's Order," to page 174. Its printed range can thus be taken as 169–173. This page ratio is not an actual count of narrative events. The original chapter includes an opening proverb, introductory information in parentheses, the dialogue between Gaurī and Burhba, three distinct temporal visions, and a song. After the conclusion, an authorial discussion begins under the title "Commentary on Chapter [−86]"; it must not be treated as a scene within the story or as a character's own account. Three questions guide this reading: what rule does the disruption of time establish within the fictional world; whose work sustains the memory of injured people's names; and what is the narrative value of connecting Yaśpati's transfer of power to injustice extending across generations?

Connection with the Previous Chapter: Political Movement after Defeat

In Chapter −87, violence against Gaurī was stopped, the land was re-entered in the community's name, and Yaśpati lost office; his will to dominate, however, had not ended. The present chapter activates that unresolved condition. News arrives that Yaśpati has gone towards the royal court at Darbhanga, presenting his journey in the language of reforming religious administration. His arrival at court, any meeting with an official, and the issuance of any new order are not directly narrated. Villagers experience relief, but Gaurī remains apprehensive. The same information produces contrasting states of knowledge in two groups of characters. Her warning—"He is merely looking for another field"—identifies the possibility that the struggle is moving to another institutional site, not a verified completed conspiracy. From this unresolved opposition, the chapter opens into a meditation on long historical time; immediate political time and the time of generations enter the same narrative fabric.

The Relieved Community and Gaurī's Unease: An Initial Difference in Focalization

The village feels relief on hearing the news, but Gaurī's discomfort embodies a different interpretation of its experience. The brief contrast holds two levels of collective psychology: the pleasure of a temporary end

to violence and an anxiety that power may seek another institutional refuge. The narrator gives prominence to Gaurī's suspicion without treating the other villagers' relief as simple stupidity; people exhausted by immediate danger may reasonably long for respite. Yet the feared political consequence at court never takes place within this chapter. It remains foreshadowing. The adversary's journey exists as reported news; its success or failure is absent. This asymmetrical distribution of knowledge draws the reader towards Gaurī's position, but the temporal visions that follow are opened by a crisis in a character's consciousness, not as an inevitable physical consequence of Yaśpati's departure.

The Chronotope of the Peepal: From Site of Memory to Gate of Time

At evening Gaurī goes to the peepal to speak to Burhba. In preceding chapters the tree concentrated memories of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā, and the dead witness. Here the same location seems to contain three distant periods. Its physical place has not changed; the range of possible perception through it has changed. This is a striking inversion of the chronotope: the shade of a local tree comes to contain an overseas port, a political field, and a future night in Channā Gāchhī. Nevertheless, the narrator never clearly establishes a rule under which the tree literally becomes a magical gateway. The experience occurs between Burhba's unstable consciousness and his dialogue with Gaurī. Literary examination should therefore initially identify it as a visionary temporal possession or unnatural apparition rather than uncritically assuming that physically sanctioned time travel has taken place.

Burhba's Unstable Body: Limited Knowledge in a Supernatural Figure

Burhba earlier appeared as a witness of memory who outlasted death and generations. His form now flickers between water and shadow, and his voice arrives in fragments through a multitude of voices. Ordinarily, a ghost's extraordinary nature might be employed to make the figure omniscient; here the text moves in the opposite direction. Burhba says, “I do not understand,” and questions his awareness of place. Supernatural existence does not provide a convenient shortcut to knowledge; the distance between experience and interpretation remains. The causes of his changing form, its duration, and the conditions governing its recurrence are, however, unspecified. This uncertainty creates wonder while leaving the internal rules of action unclear. His inability can be compared with the extinguished torch of the preceding chapter: power and limitation appear to vary according to the demands of the immediate plot.

First Glimpse: An Overseas Contract and Consent without Literacy

The first vision depicts a distant harbour: a ship emitting black smoke, people carrying bundles, a recruiting intermediary promising money, and a young man placing his thumbprint on an unfamiliar document. Labour migration is not represented as a matter of choice alone, but as a compound circumstance of hope, fear, unequal language rights, and economic power. The recruiter promises an attractive three-year contract; the young man, unable to read it, cannot inspect its conditions. His thumbprint opens a distinction between consent appearing on a document and consent informed by an understanding of its terms. The text does not disclose his final destination, subsequent employment conditions, or whether the contract was broken. This image must not be represented as a documentary record of a specific historical ship or body of workers. It is an imagined but socially meaningful configuration of economic domination.

"1885": Conjecture, History, and the Limits of Narrative Evidence

Burhba asks, "Is this … is this 1885?" The interrogative form is crucial. The narrator does not state as an independently verified fact that a named vessel sailed in 1885; Burhba is trying to assign a date to an experience he himself cannot confidently locate. The year must therefore be treated as a narrative indication, not archival proof. Research into the actual history of overseas labour migration from India could be brought into conversation with this episode, but the chapter gives no name of vessel, port of departure, destination, or documentary reference. Conflating a historical category with a fictional scene to make an unsupported historical claim would contradict the evidentiary responsibilities of the Videha Parallel History approach. That approach attends to the experiences of neglected workers while explicitly retaining the limits of its sources.

The Contract: From a Right to One's Name to Legal Invisibility

The first vision gives the book's broad theme of the "name" a particular paradox. The youth puts his thumbprint on the paper but cannot understand the words to which it is attached. In the eyes of a legal document he may appear to have "agreed," while his capacity to choose is impaired by lack of information. In Chapter –92, Sukhdev Mahto's time and claim to land had been obstructed by procedural rules; in Chapter –87 the leatherworkers' quarter had its collective name restored to a land record. Here the presence of a person's mark on paper is itself insufficient to protect rights. Manuscript, title deed, and overseas contract are three different objects, yet they prompt a common question: whose language, whose control, and whose understanding shape the document? The conjunction enriches the document-consciousness of the larger narrative.

But because the young man is not named, he remains a representative image rather than a fully individuated life.

Second Glimpse: A Land Struggle and a Moment of Repression

The second temporal vision combines a parched field, a gathering of people, a young woman shouting slogans into a microphone, police batons, and a stampede. "The land belongs to the one who tills it!" becomes the central cry of the movement. The scene offers a forceful immediate image of social struggle but cannot be identified with a particular historical event: its leader, organization, location, year, and outcome remain unknown. The young woman has a public voice yet serves largely as a sign of the movement. The text does not tell us which cultivating community she belongs to, how she chose to act, or what happened to her after the repression. The first vision showed a young man's silent thumbprint; the second shows a young woman's powerful utterance. This shift in linguistic authority suggests historical movement, while the police response and the destruction of papers warn that public speech does not guarantee rights.

Resemblance to Sukhdev's Document: Formal Echo, Not Repetition

Seeing a partition deed crushed amid the tumult, Gaurī reacts as though she recognizes Sukhdev's paper. Burhba immediately corrects her: "This is not Sukhdev's paper." The denial is decisive to the narrative's reasoning. The second vision is not the literal recurrence of the earlier incident: the object, the time, and the people are different. The common pattern lies in the destruction of documentary evidence, insecurity of land rights, and suppression of the disadvantaged. This is an intranarrative or intertextual echo, not an assertion that a single event has occurred twice. Ignoring the distinction would distort any count of events. At the same time, the narrator's thematic claim that history takes "the same shape" under different names can suppress the distinctive causes and institutional circumstances of different land struggles. This double possibility is both an achievement and a limitation.

Third Glimpse: Kabaddi in Channā Gāchhī and the Future-Oriented Narrative

The third glimpse contains Channā Gāchhī, a night-time kabaddi game, dead players, a figure acting as referee, and living children mingling with the dead. Compared with the first two politically recognizable images, it is openly unnatural. Players' feet rising above the ground, a worn conch, and a silver-bright figure transform symbols into the substance of a scene. Gaurī does not recognize the name Channā Gāchhī, a small but important confirmation of the limits of her present knowledge. The

reader receives a possible link with future chapters, while the character does not know in what era the episode is located. Burhba's interpretation permits the description of a vision of the future, but the fulfillment of every detail is not independently established in this chapter. The sequence functions as an anticipatory bridge between parts of the narrative.

Spectator and Focalization: Who Sees the Visions?

The narrator describes the scenes vividly, but Burhba's wavering perception and Gaurī's questions mediate the presentation. In the first glimpse Gaurī does not know the ship's name; in the second she recognizes a resemblance between documents; in the third the grove's name remains unfamiliar to her. An apparently comprehensive pictorial account and the characters' bounded knowledge coexist in the same passages. The narrator gives ship, baton, dead players, and children a fully imagined visibility, yet if their physical mode of appearance is the consciousness of two characters, whose experience actually contains the images? The Genettean questions "Who sees?" and "Who speaks?" must therefore be kept apart. The gap between Burhba's uncertain utterances and the narrator's visual certainty introduces cognitive instability; it cannot be dismissed simply as an error or affirmed as uncomplicated omniscience.

Another Form of Himself: The Climactic Paradox of Time

The figure presiding in the tree holds a conch and sits above the earth. Burhba cries out, "That is me!" At this point a theory of time becomes more than verbal discourse. A character has the impossible experience of seeing another version of himself. In the first two visions he observed the time of other people; in the third his own identity is placed in question. Seeing oneself in two places, the objective simultaneity of both forms, and their belonging to one consciousness are three distinct propositions. The original establishes the first experience and does not demonstrate the answers to the others. The resulting wonder depends on this indeterminacy. There is also a risk: if every exceptional impossibility is permitted by the temporal rules, the reader's confidence in irreversible consequences may diminish. Later chapters will have to be examined to determine how far that danger is controlled.

River and Crocodile: A Theory of Time through Metaphor

Burhba revises his former understanding: time once seemed to him "a river"; now it seems "a crocodile." The flowing river is an accessible image of one-directional succession; a crocodile, though belonging to the stream, can move back and forth within it. The metaphor joins the reversal of temporal sequence, destruction across generations, and the survival of memory in a single symbolic field. But metaphor, the physics of

time, and narrative order are not identical. Showing a future scene earlier in a text is a disturbance of narrative order; allowing a character to behold another time is an unnatural condition within the fictional world; calling time a crocodile is a symbolic or philosophical proposal. They should not be turned into one literal rule. Separating the levels does not lessen the metaphor's power; it clarifies its different forms of activity.

"It Cannot Devour Names": The Shield of Memory and Its Social Condition

Burhba's statement "But it cannot devour names" is the chapter's emotional centre. Violence can destroy bodies, but a name may survive through communal speech. The sentence is not, however, a universal empirical truth. The names of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sukhdev survive because someone has written them, spoken them, remembered them, and decided to pass them on. The unnamed youth at the harbour, the unnamed woman in the land movement, and the many migrants aboard the ship expose a contradiction: if a name has not entered a record, whose memory will preserve it? The immortality of a name thus depends less on an eternal divine attribute than on shared labour, documentation, struggle, and the continual remaking of language. The narrative's own examples limit the unlimited promise of its symbol. The tension is productively critical if the reader perceives the question of those who have been forgotten.

Gaurī's Question: The Claim of a Future Female Voice

When Gaurī asks about the children in the third vision, she comes to question the possibility of another version of herself in the future. Her inquiry—"Did you see me as well?"—is not mere self-preoccupation. She fears the return of injustice against women's bodies across generations. Burhba's answer speaks of a pair of resolute but frightened eyes. He does not give a name, date, or determinate physical identity. It is not established that the second woman must be Gaurī reborn. The work offers an intergenerational resemblance of perspective, courage, and fear rather than a demonstrated recurrence of the same body. Gaurī's question claims a place for women's experience in future history, though the future woman's independent life remains undefined. That ignorance leaves room for ethical expansion while risking reduction of characters to symbolic doubles.

Burhba's Ethical Strength: The Decision Not to Lie

Burhba wishes to spare Gaurī pain but says, "I shall not lie to you." Within the story this is a significant ethical event. The supernatural seer's knowledge is uncertain: he cannot identify the future year or the name of its calamity, yet he refuses to conceal the limit of what he has perceived. In

the scrutiny of evidence, a speaker's sincerity does not establish that every inference the speaker makes is true. Burhba may be trustworthy as a character without becoming an independently verified source for future history. Reassurance and fear coexist in the utterance. The refusal to give Gaurī a wholly certain answer is an intellectual restraint whose consistency must still be examined in subsequent chapters.

Children of the Future: An Unknown Route of Transmission

Burhba believes that children of a later period have heard the stories of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā, Mālatī, and Viśvanāth. He conjectures that someone far ahead will gather these narratives together. The self-referentiality is clear: a reader holding the combined trilogy may recognize a reflection of the possible future collector of stories. Yet the channel by which those names were transmitted—song, manuscript, women's testimony, oral account, or collected writing—is not fully identified within the story. This incomplete medium invites investigation into the institutions that preserve memory. Were the book eventually to claim itself as memory's sole guardian, the social plurality of voices would risk contraction. Here Burhba's "perhaps" retains the proposition at the level of conjecture.

Unnatural Narrative and the Rules of a Possible World

The unnatural feature here is not simply decorative fantasy: someone belonging to an earlier time sees a future ghostly version of himself. The text nevertheless retains three restraints. Gaurī does not physically travel to the other locations; Burhba does not know the cause of the visions; and none of them immediately changes the village's current political situation. These restrictions prevent the fictional world from becoming entirely unconstrained. Within possible-world analysis the visions may be experiences of another time or of a possible future, rather than newly created alternative presents. Whether they are definite objective images of what must happen remains undecided. Nor will it suffice to reduce the temporal rupture to ordinary flashback or foreshadowing alone. An impossible experience at the level of character and anticipation at the level of narration reinforce each other.

Examining Claims through Pakṣa, Hetu, and Vyāpti

Several assertions require separate assessments. First, the news that Yaśpati has gone towards the court has a verbally transmitted source within the narrative; it gives no evidence of the consequences at court. Second, Burhba's report of seeing another form of himself describes a character's visual experience; it cannot establish a universal theory of two objective identities or of time. Third, resemblance between a future woman and

Gaurī cannot by itself demonstrate rebirth or historical identity; inferring identity from similarity risks a fallacious ground. Fourth, the remembrance of names for a few generations cannot prove their indestructibility for all time. The object under examination changes in each case: an observed vision, belief, history, and symbol are different referents. This constitutes a critical application of Navya-Nyāya's sensitivity to distinctions, not an invented quotation from a classical aphorism.

Videha Parallel History: The Time of the Neglected and the Archive

The overseas labourer, the tenant or cultivator without secure rights, the repressed protester, the female witness, and the children of the future do not occupy the centre of a conventional chronology of royal events. The narrative places the strands of their experience beside news of courts and offices. It thereby raises a central question of parallel history: states measure time through governments, decrees, and dynasties; people also measure it through lost homes, erased papers, women's voices, and names that survive. Yet ethical responsibility in writing parallel history does not permit fictional examples to be presented as undocumented proof of real events. The youth's contract, the young woman's demonstration, and the conjectured 1885 setting are creations within the novel. They pose questions for independent archival research; the novel is not itself the documentation of each represented historical occurrence.

Indian Poetics: Wonder, Pathos, and Suggestion Together

Burhba's divided appearance and the sight of himself elsewhere create the possibility of adbhuta, wonder. The illiterate thumbprint on a contract and the sight of batons in the demonstration bring pathos and fear into conjunction. The crocodile of time is an oblique, vakrokti-like transformation of the river image: time ceases to be water alone and becomes a dangerous creature hidden within it. The statement about the survival of names suggests that written power may disappear while collective voices of remembrance may return. But aucitya poses a question: does the swift movement from labour oppression aboard a ship to spectral kabaddi create an excessive emotional leap? The narrator joins them through a single astonishing vision, mediated by Burhba's fear, rather than through an elaborated historical argument. This is a legitimate object of stylistic criticism.

Narrative Order, Duration, and Event Density

The event-map runs as follows: news of Yaśpati's departure towards court; Gaurī's unease; Burhba's instability at the peepal; the maritime vision; the land-struggle vision; spectral kabaddi with the living and the dead;

Burhba's crisis of self-recognition; the crocodile-of-time metaphor; Gaurī's question about the future; Burhba's bounded answer; his partial recovery of stability; Gaurī's extended, unanswered question; and the song. The three distant scenes are not direct political events taking place in the village's present. They are separate units at the level of experience. Yaśpati's actual journey and the villagers' responses alter the current setting; the temporal scenes change Burhba's and Gaurī's knowledge; no land title or administrative decision is newly changed within this chapter. Duration is compressed in the visions, expanded in the dialogue, and stretched across vast time in the final summary of possible futures.

The Limits of Temporal Incongruity: Three Unequally Developed Scenes

The first scene concerns a ship, contract, and an individual's decision; the second a movement, repression, and the destruction of a document; the third a game of ghosts and astonished children. One might discern an imagined sequence of economic subjection, struggle over social rights, and cultural revival through memory. But the novel does not show a direct historical chain joining these images. It does not establish that the emigrant's descendants joined the later protest, or that those protesters were ancestors of the children in the grove. What connects the scenes is thematic form, not a documented miniature chronology. Their images are powerful, but the characters' namelessness, limited social detail, and missing year-by-year transitions prevent their treatment as a complete history of multiple ages.

Song and Authorial Note: Two Separate Levels of Interpretation

In the closing proverb sung by Burhba, the survival of names becomes the communal counter-formula to destructive time. The song gives the experiences an emotional conclusion, repeating the initial assertion without producing a new argumentative answer. Repetition operates deliberately as a folk technique of retention, while also reducing three complex images to the simple opposition that time consumes and names endure. The subsequent authorial note describes non-linear time as a literary device and connects the chapter to later events in Channā Gāchhī. It also refers to a "project of ten complete volumes," whereas the available combined trilogy is organized into three volumes. The mismatch is not evidence that missing volumes must exist; it is an inconsistency between a paratextual editorial claim and the available form of the work. The narrative should be assessed through its scenes, the note through its own editorial claims.

The Meaning of Gaurī's Last Question: Old Injustice in a New Face

Returning home, Gaurī wonders whether the danger embodied by Yaśpati is new or an old calamity returning. The political news at the beginning thus becomes an ethical question again at the end. Although it disrupts linear chronology, the chapter is circular in its external frame: it begins with news of Yaśpati's departure and ends by questioning the possibility of his return in a different shape. Burhba's visions give Gaurī's political judgement a language of long pasts and futures. A danger nevertheless remains: if every new wrong is treated as merely an "old shape," the particular laws, economic relationships, and responsibilities of different historical periods may disappear from view. Gaurī frames the issue as a question rather than a verdict. That openness preserves the right to examine new times on their own terms and gives the ending more critical power than a simple prediction of revenge.

Literary Achievement, Limitations, and Place in the Larger Sequence

The chapter's principal achievement is to connect philosophical debate in the remote prehistory of the story, documentary helplessness among workers, cultivators' struggles over land, and the folklore of future generations through one sensuous metaphor of time. Burhba's ignorance and astonishment, rather than his omniscience, become the centre of the reader's inquiry. Gaurī's autonomous political warning and her question about the future female voice retain the importance of women's present experience within the vast temporal scheme. The limitations are substantial as well. The first two visions are highly schematic; individual life stories are thin; the physical rules of time-vision remain unsettled; 1885 is not independently established; the identity of another Gaurī remains uncertain; the song simplifies the scenes; and the reference to ten volumes conflicts with the available three-volume text. These discrepancies should be recorded without conflating them. "The Crocodile of Time" is a narrative junction between immediate danger and an extended people's history, but its temporal imagination must be read with the limits of social and epistemic evidence in view.

Chapter –86: Events, Illustrative Scenes, and Evidentiary Limits

Narrative point	Evidence in the original chapter	Outcome	Evidentiary limit
Yaśpati leaves for the court	Village news and a claim of reform	Villagers feel relief; Gaurī remains apprehensive	No actual court action shown here
Gaurī's political warning	Statement that he will seek another arena	Threat posed by the opponent remains	Future conspiracy remains conjectural
Burhba's instability near the peepal	Flickering form and broken voice	A crisis in the witness-character's knowledge	Physical cause unresolved

Narrative point	Evidence in the original chapter	Outcome	Evidentiary limit
Scene of an overseas contract	Ship, recruiting agent, thumbprint of an illiterate youth	Unequality in documentary consent	Ship, country, people, and event records unidentified
The date 1885	Burhba's interrogative guess	A provisional chronological thread to the first glimpse	Not a verified historical date
Scene of a land movement	Young woman's slogan and police baton	Pattern of repression and resistance	Place, date, leader, outcome unknown
Resemblance to Sukhdev's deed	Gaurī tries to identify it; Burhba denies the identity	History takes a recurrent form	It is not the very same partition deed
Kabaddi at Channā Gāchhī	Dead player and living child	Symbolic foreshadowing of later narrative	Not a direct event of the present
Burhba recognises himself	He sees another form of himself on a tree	Supernatural uncertainty concerning time	Material existence of the second form unproven
River becomes crocodile	Burhba revises his metaphor of time	Dramatic rendering of a vision of time	Not a scientific theory of time
Gaurī questions the future	Indication of a second eye and new disaster	Women's experience across generations	Rebirth or identity of persons unproven
Argument for safeguarding names	Burhba's assurance and the possibility of a future collector	Ethical emphasis on folk remembrance	Not all unnamed people are automatically preserved
Burhba partly steadies	Altered state at the end of the night	Lasting effect of experience	Detailed laws of time remain unspecified
Gaurī's final question	Old disaster returns with a new face	Circular transition from the news of Yaśpati	No proof of a new event or offence
Song and authorial note	Repeated folk maxim and discussion of disrupted chronology	Story and paratext form distinct levels of meaning	Ten sections of the note do not match the available trilogy

The table distinguishes events narrated in the present from Burhba's visions, Gaurī's inferences, the narrator's figures of speech, and the post-chapter note. No prophetic image is treated as an independent historical record.

Chapter −86: Verified Register of Evidence from the Original Text

Opening proverb — "Time, too, is a crocodile."

Gaurī's political apprehension — "He is merely looking for another field."

Burhba's admission of limited knowledge — "I do not understand."

Recruiter's promise — "A three-year contract."

Unequal knowledge of the contract — "A paper that he could not read."

Burhba's tentative date — "Is this … is this 1885?"

Slogan in the second glimpse — "The land belongs to the one who tills it!"

Gaurī's initial comparison — "Sukhdev's paper!"

Burhba's clarification — "This is not Sukhdev's paper."

Formal echo of history — "As though that story were being written anew."

Third vision's location — "Channā Gāchh."

Sound of the future game — "Kabaddi ... kabaddi ..."

Burhba's crisis of self-recognition — "That is me."

Problem of simultaneity — "In two places at once."

Earlier temporal image — "A river."

Revised temporal image — "It is a crocodile."

Survival of names — "But it cannot devour names."

Possibility of a future collector — "Perhaps ... perhaps someone."

Gaurī's forward-looking question — "Did you see me as well?"

Burhba's limited truthfulness — "I shall not lie to you."

Unknown future date — "What year was it?"

Resemblance across generations — "As resolute as you."

Closing political question — "With a new face."

Closing proverb — "That which dwells in memory."

Critical Section 16 | Original Chapter −85 — The Āmil's Order

Textual Basis, Page Range, and Critical Questions

"The Āmil's Order" is the sixteenth independent chapter in the period of prehistory. The contents of the original combined trilogy place its opening on printed page 174 and that of Chapter −84, "The Silence of the Forest," on page 180. The relevant page range is thus 174–179; it does not follow that every quotation has thereby been assigned a verified individual page number. The percentage mentioned later in the critical account is only an initial mechanical indicator, not a measure of actual narrative event density. The central question is how a royal order, a tree serving as a communal repository of memory, a supernatural appearance, and the absence of a record provide evidence about one another—or place one another in doubt.

The Link with the Previous Chapter: An Administrative Assault after Temporal Vision

Chapter −86 had left Burhba's visions of the future uncertain even to him. The next stage gives a local and institutional form to the fear of unknown time. Yaśpati returns from the Darbhanga royal court with Āmil Jayasiṃha and ten soldiers. The parenthetical notice tells the reader in advance that the target is no longer merely Gaurī or the leatherworkers' settlement but "the peepal witness-tree itself." This announcement does not eliminate all suspense but establishes the direction of confrontation. In the preceding chapter the question was whether names might survive the passage of time; here their physical place of public remembrance may be cut down. The narrative contracts from a panorama of history to a rapid political conflict occurring within one day.

The Order's Narrative Function: Turning Opposition into Legal Procedure

Jayasiṃha's arrival on an elephant and the proclamation fastened at the public square are visual signs of authority. Issued in the name of a "Department for the Administration of Religion," the order identifies the peepal as a "centre of tantric malpractice and superstition." The language does not initiate impartial scientific inquiry; a purported conclusion has already entered the premise. By placing "investigation" and "eradication if necessary" in the same administrative sentence, the possibility of felling the tree acquires institutional sanction from the beginning. A proposed royal granary supplies a public-interest justification for the intervention,

but the narrative never explains why a granary must necessarily be built on precisely this spot. The document is therefore more than an object in the story: it is a device for making a violent intervention appear legitimate.

State Language and Yaśpati's Language: Two Powers in a Temporary Alliance

Yaśpati declares, "I have brought the power of science and the state." The coupling matters. Previously he relied on religious fear in the witchcraft accusation; now he deploys the state's professed rationality as a weapon against the last refuge of the leatherworkers' settlement. Jayasiṃha, by contrast, speaks in a neutral, "almost kindly" tone in his first exchange. Reading the two men as one fixed villain would miss this distinction. Their interests coincide at that moment, but Yaśpati's private desire for land and Jayasiṃha's position as an administrator have different structures. That difference gives meaning to Jayasiṃha's later decision, although it does not amount to his complete moral rehabilitation.

A One-Sided Rule of Evidence: Making the Tree's Rights Conditional

Phulesarī immediately sees the difficulty in the Āmil's proposal: "If we lose, the tree will be cut; even if we win, the burden of evidence is still ours." No balanced mode of inquiry has been established. Villagers are required to demonstrate extraordinary power, but the administration is not made to prove that destroying the tree is justified. Gaurī's claim that it is a site of folk memory, grief, and justice could establish ordinary social and environmental reasons to protect it. Instead the order makes its survival dependent upon a test of supernatural force. This binary opposition between "reform" and "superstition" excludes the real questions of land rights and collective remembrance. Phulesarī's short observation constitutes the chapter's sharpest institutional criticism.

The Irony of a Scientific Test: The Prospect of Destruction before Inquiry

Jayasiṃha says, "If there truly is some power here, my axe will be unable to harm it." The proposal is contradictory on its own terms. How can an inquiry into whether a power prevents harm justify striking a tree before establishing any necessity for damage? Even if it is merely an ordinary living tree, its felling requires a distinct justification. No necessary connection has been supplied between the proposition that "supernatural power is absent" and the conclusion that "cutting is just." The criticism is therefore not opposition to science, but opposition to an inappropriate test conducted in the name of science with its outcome substantially predetermined. Whether Jayasiṃha is truly prepared to act with

intellectual integrity must be judged by his subsequent conduct, not by his claim to neutrality alone.

Gaurī and Sāvitrī: The Subtle Arrangement of an Inheritance of Memory

Gaurī enters the crowd holding the hand of her eight-year-old daughter Sāvitrī. The child has repeatedly woken at night saying that "someone is crying near the peepal." Her words serve as a familial indication in support of Gaurī's belief that Burhba is disturbed, but they do not independently establish the external truth of the experience. This distinction is important. The novel draws a line of memory from Budhua's transformation in an earlier generation to the testimony of a new generation of women. Gaurī holding Sāvitrī's hand gives visual form to inheritance, but the child has not yet been granted a decisive public voice. Her sensitivity becomes a seed for future narration; for the moment her principal action is to make the social danger to Gaurī more tangible.

Spatial Composition: From the Public Square to the Peepal Roots

The proclamation hangs at the public square; the decisive confrontation occurs at the roots of the peepal. The first location belongs to the state's written language and its assembled public, the second to communal memory and directly experienced collective presence. Together they give substance to the contrast between "paper" and "leaf" in the opening proverb. The elephant, soldiers, axe, and proclamation are signs of projected authority. Children, the whispers of women, Gaurī beside the roots, and remembered names are finer signs of a communal place. Through this opposition, the episode exceeds a mere ghostly apparition and asks whose knowledge and rights count as decisive in public space.

The Duration of One Day and the Decisive Pause

The chapter begins with the Āmil's entry "one morning"; the axe strikes at "midday"; and "that evening" Jayasiṃha returns towards the royal court. These three indications establish the principal action within one day. Yet two sentences abruptly slow time: "The first axe struck the root," followed by "Stop." A single blow is succeeded by general stillness, and the change in duration intensifies the crisis. Compared with the broad period of preceding history, this is a dense dramatic scene. "The following week" and "the following month" then return Yaśpati's absence to summary. The narrative moves deliberately between an immediate scene and extended uncertainty.

The Unnatural Voice: Identification through Negation

The voice rising near the tree is described by excluding determinate identities: "neither a woman's, nor a man's, neither a human's, nor an animal's." Thousands of throats seem to speak together without the appearance of additional mouths. This is a possible event under the convention of unnatural narration; its verification through the acoustics of the external world is not the task of literary criticism. The fourfold negation releases the voice from fixed gender, species, and source. Its sole command, "Stop," makes its narrative purpose plain: not to increase destruction, but to prevent the felling of the tree. Even so, the sudden supernatural intervention changes the relative weight of victory won by human resistance, a risk that needs examination.

Burhba's Appearance: The Limited Credibility of an Extraordinary Sight

A figure "trembling between smoke and light" renders Burhba visible without turning him into a wholly material body. The narrator claims that villagers had previously seen only an indistinct shadow; this is his first clear appearance in daylight. Jayasiṃha is astonished, the soldiers retreat, and Yaśpati calls the sight an illusion. The description of a collective experience confers importance upon it within the fictional world, but its credibility in that world is not an archival proof in the reader's historical world. Shared perception and externally verified fact must remain distinct.

"I Am a Witness": Ethical Position Rather than Power

When Jayasiṃha asks, "Who are you?", Burhba answers, "I am a witness." He refuses both the designation of deity and that of demon. This choice is highly significant. Burhba does not wish to be merely a source of marvels but a remembering presence positioned between names, deaths, and oblivion. Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā, Mālatī, and Subhāgī are named once again: stories dispersed across numerous preceding chapters return in a single utterance. Yet one question remains. Does remembering automatically deliver justice, or must living communities act upon memory? Burhba's own words favour the latter, since he challenges what the state intends to do to the tree.

The Tree's Existence and the Witness's Age Are Not Identical

Burhba says, "I am older than this tree." This does not establish that Burhba and the peepal are one being. The tree is a communal site of memory; Burhba is memory personified in the story. The distinction makes it possible, within the fiction, that Burhba might survive even if the tree were cut. Why then should the tree be protected? The answer lies not

merely in ghostly existence but in neglected people's memories, collective mourning, and an inhabited relationship with place. Protecting the tree does not mean preserving Burhba's physical body; it means protecting a public site of remembrance. Environmental narration and the criticism of alternative archives touch here without becoming identical.

The Limits of State Knowledge: The Impulse to Destroy What Is Not Understood

Burhba asks whether the state can "cut down everything that it cannot understand." His question is the chapter's philosophical centre. Ignorance is not merely a lack of knowledge; in the hands of an administration it may become a pretext for punishment. State power may deny the right of a thing to exist because it cannot categorize it. Yet Burhba's utterance should not be turned into an argument against every conceivable official inquiry. The relevant case is specific: Yaśpati is a private instigator of the plan to fell the tree, and the process has not provided an adequate hearing of the villagers' distinct interests. The moral objection has force because of these particulars.

Jayasiṃha's Transformation: Experience, Judgment, and Administrative Constraint

After hearing the voice and seeing the figure, Jayasiṃha commands, "Put down the axe." The narrator notes a "new and uneasy respect" in him. This is more than the straightforward humiliation of a villain: an agent of the state changes a decision because of a personal experience. He publicly identifies Yaśpati's desire for land. The turn is nevertheless extraordinarily rapid—a supernatural image, followed immediately by an official command. No independently documented inquiry into local testimony, reconsideration of the written order, or examination of the land dispute is staged. The scene offers a powerful shift from pathos to wonder, but it is not a complete portrayal of institutional justice.

Illusion and Truth: A Cautious Epistemic Examination

Jayasiṃha himself says, "I know how to distinguish illusion from truth." The grounds of his decision, however, remain limited in the text: an unexpected voice, a visible figure, and collective fear. If the proposition under inquiry is that an extraordinary witness-being exists at the site, then an inference from visual experience would require examination of the ground's accuracy, competing explanations, its necessary relation to the conclusion, and the remaining doubts. Collective experience alone does not automatically exclude every possible illusion. More importantly, the possibility of an unimaginable being within the fictional world and proof of such a being in the historical world are distinct propositions. The

author makes Burhba's ethical speech the centre of decision. Literary effectiveness does not make that procedure unassailable as a demonstration in epistemology.

The Exposure of Yaśpati's Motive: Inference and Achievement

Jayasiṃha tells Yaśpati, "This is not for the tree; this is for the land of the leatherworkers' settlement." The reader can support that conclusion through the plots shown in Chapters –88 and –87, so the exposure does not seem wholly arbitrary. Yet Jayasiṃha himself presents no new land document or formal investigation of the wrongdoing in this scene. The reader knows more about the earlier events than the Āmil has been shown discovering. This inequality of knowledge makes his declaration narratively plausible without supplying the missing judicial evidentiary process. It is a moral unveiling, not a formal verdict.

A Convenient Escape: The Soldiers' Inaction and Plotting Ease

Yaśpati runs away; Jayasiṃha orders, "Stop him!" The soldiers, still terrified by the apparition, hesitate, and Yaśpati disappears into the forest. One explanation lies within the immediate scene: the soldiers have been stunned. Nevertheless, the ability of an instigator to escape an armed public assembly and reach the forest is also a convenient device for sustaining mystery. The physical circumstances of his flight are dispatched in too few sentences. Greater attention to the failure of pursuit would have strengthened event credibility. The narrative here favours visual excitement over the administrative consequences of the attempted arrest.

Recommended Protection versus an Actual Right

Jayasiṃha promises that he will "recommend" royal protection for Gaurī's land, the tree, and the community's rights. The grammar of this promise matters. "I shall recommend protection" is a future undertaking; it is not the same as "protection has been granted." The tree is saved from being cut on this occasion, but the text does not demonstrate that an enforceable state guarantee of land rights has been issued. There is no order number, executed document, or subsequent enforcement. The novel intensifies this incompletion through the missing report. A moral victory and an institutional achievement therefore require separate accounts.

The Missing Report: Absence from the Archive Becomes Part of the Story

Villagers speculate for years about Jayasiṃha's report, but, according to the narrator, "the report was never found in any archive." This claim belongs to the fictional narrative and is not a finding from independent research in the real Darbhanga archives. In the story, its absence opens two

contrasting possibilities: the state may have suppressed a decision, or an occurrence preserved in communal memory may never have received accessible official confirmation. The narrator does not resolve the alternatives. The opening contrast between “on paper” and “on a leaf” consequently becomes more complicated. A paper may once have been written but is now unavailable, while collective speech continues.

Burhba's Ignorance: A Check upon the Omniscient Ghost

In a final private exchange Burhba says, “I could not see Yaśpati's end.” His vision across time stops at the entrance to the forest. This acknowledgement prevents the figure from becoming an invariably omniscient helper. Although the narrative has made him the focus of a shared supernatural occurrence before Jayasiṃha, it closes by disclosing a boundary of his knowledge. The new uncertainty may generate apprehension about future harm, but Yaśpati's death, the destination of his flight, and the action of any unseen forest power have not been established. “It frightens me” describes the experienced character's fear, not a demonstrated prophecy. The chapter thereby opens an effective question for “The Silence of the Forest.”

Gaurī's Reply: The Philosophical Meaning of Love as Remembrance

When Jayasiṃha asks what kind of power has manifested, Gaurī replies that it is “neither sorcery nor a god.” A person's decision never to forget another's name may be “stronger than time.” This answer is an ethical metaphor, not a physical explanation of the miracle. Giving remembrance power over time is not a scientific theory, but a valuation of communal resistance to death and anonymity. The sentence reasserts the older theme of the name within the epic narrative. The social effects of remembrance must nevertheless remain connected with the protection of actual land, distribution of food, and prevention of violence. The utterance of names alone does not end injustice.

The Returning Folk Song: A Transformation of the Paper–Leaf Contrast

The opening proverb sets the “sahib's order on paper” against “the village's justice on a leaf.” The villagers expand it in the closing song: “Paper may tear,” while “the saying remains in the throat.” The recurrence is not mere decoration. At first the line voices the imminent threat of cutting down the tree; later it contrasts the temporariness of the state's written order with the long communal life of oral witness. The saying places resistance within a broader perspective of time. Yet the song's confident moral pattern also flattens internal difficulties: Jayasiṃha's limited change, the

missing report, and Yaśpati's escape are not equally present in its victorious tone.

Focalization: Jayasiṃha, Gaurī, Burhba, and the Crowd

The narrator speaks in the third person, but the focal position is not held by one character. Yaśpati's satisfaction, Gaurī's effort to steady her voice, the soldiers' fear, Jayasiṃha's developing respect, and Burhba's private apprehension are presented successively. The broad range of knowledge means that the reader understands Yaśpati's intention before Jayasiṃha has been shown learning it. At one point, an assertion that "every person in the village" hears the voice is a sweeping narratorial statement, different from any individual's limited experience. Finally, the private conversation between Burhba and Gaurī contracts the scene after the public assembly. Unless these levels of knowledge are separated, the words of an ostensibly omniscient narrator may mistakenly be treated as historical evidence.

Event Density: An Account of Independent Changes

The main events of a single day produce a series of changes from the original threat to the tree: the Āmil's entrance; the written order; Gaurī's public objection; unequal terms of inquiry; the first blow of the axe; the voice and figure; the command to cease felling; the exposure of Yaśpati's motive; his flight; the promise of a royal recommendation; the report's disappearance; and Burhba's fear of the unknown. This is an analytical event sequence, not an automatically decisive count. A long speech may hold several ethical propositions without constituting several independent external events. The earlier figure of 55.6 per cent action-indicating paragraphs does not replace such qualitative distinctions.

Indian Poetics: Wonder, the Suggestion of Pathos, and Propriety

The voice of thousands and the figure of smoke and light following the axe-blow evoke adbhuta rasa. But this wonder is grounded in the remembered lives of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, and others; karuṇa, the suggestion of suffering, penetrates the miraculous scene. The opposition between paper and leaf is a compressed vakrokti-like image of the distance between institutional proof and folk memory. A difficult question of aucitya remains. Although independent human arguments for the tree's social rights were available, its preservation depends principally upon a ghost's visible intervention. The apparition is imaginatively effective, but its necessity and its relationship to human decision-making remain open to examination.

Videha Parallel History: Names, Women's Testimony, and Invisible Records

Burhba's list consists chiefly of those whose names did not enter the state's papers. The right to bear witness also appears in Gaurī's memory and Phulesarī's questioning. Folk song, the peepal, and collective utterance work as figures of an alternative archive. This does not remove the need for written records. Indeed, the missing report shows that official documentation remains necessary to secure rights over land for marginalized communities. The strength of parallel history lies in this double demand: expose the written silence of dominant history, and do not automatically treat every claim made by popular memory as independently proven fact. This distinction preserves both sympathy and critical scrutiny.

Post-Chapter Commentary: An Explanatory Level Apart from the Story

After the closing song, the original includes "Commentary on Chapter [–85]" and a discussion of "the conflict between anti-superstition reform and local tradition." The note offers a general warning about the destruction of marginalized communities' practices in the name of reform and suggests that Jayasiṃha is neither a wholly evil figure nor a saviour. These statements express the author's interpretive intention; they are not additional events in the plot. The sociological proposition should not be turned into established universal history without independent research, but it provides a significant paratextual indication for interpreting changes in Jayasiṃha's manner and conduct. The main narrative, song, and commentary are different levels of evidence.

Achievements, Limits, and the Opening towards the Next Chapter

The achievement of "The Āmil's Order" is to connect Gaurī's land dispute with the public meaning of the witness-tree, the oppressive potential of written authority, and the ethical preservation of names. Phulesarī exposes the subtle defect of a one-sided burden of proof; Burhba's self-description as witness brings the earlier dead back into the present; and Jayasiṃha's limited change suggests that administrative judgment may contain possibilities of conscience. The limits are equally clear: an apparition abruptly concludes the decisive test; the unjust requirement of proving the tree's extraordinary powers remains implicitly accepted; the judicial inquiry is compressed; Yaśpati escapes conveniently; and a formal record of lasting protection is absent. At the close Burhba cannot see into the forest, making the next chapter, –84, "The Silence of the Forest," an open question.

Chapter −85: Event, Cause, Decision, and Evidentiary Limits

No.	Event or form in the text	Narrative transformation	Available basis	Unresolved limit
1	Āmil, soldiers, and Yaśpati arrive	Royal scrutiny bears down on the village	Elephant procession and written proclamation	Historical existence of the named department independently unconfirmed
2	Order to investigate or destroy the witness-tree	Site of folk memory risks being cut down	Allegations of tantric superstition; plan for granary	No concrete example of actual harm from the tree
3	Gaurī objects in public	State accusation opens questions of memory and rights	Village memory, grief, and site of justice	Value of memory does not prove extraordinary power
4	Phulesarī identifies unequal terms	A one-sided burden of proof falls on the community	Analysis of both winning and losing	No independent, impartial inquiry
5	Axe strikes and a voice calls “Stop”	An investigation becomes an immediate danger scene	Sound and soldiers' response	Extraordinary voice is evidence only within the fiction
6	Burhba's visible appearance	Shared experience joins the narrative of witnessing	Repetition of Hulāsā's and others' names	No external verification of a supernatural claim
7	Jayasiṃha orders the cutting stopped	Immediate protection of the tree	“Put down the axe”	Full implementation of royal protection not established
8	Yaśpati's hunger for land is exposed	The official's moral viewpoint changes	Āmil's direct accusation	No formal criminal investigation shown
9	Yaśpati flees into the forest	Opponent disappears; mystery remains	Soldiers' fear; failed pursuit	His death or destination unknown
10	Protection is recommended; the report cannot be found	Moral victory alongside an archival gap	Assurance and missing report	Recommendation is not a completed royal order
11	Burhba's gaze stops at the forest	Uncertainty for the next chapter	Private dialogue with Gaurī	Not a certain prediction of disaster
12	The opening proverb returns	Folk archive contrasted with fragile paper	Closing communal song	Song is not a plot event, but an ethical reframing

Chapter −85: Verified Register of Quotations from the Original Text

01. Opening proverb — “The sahib's order on paper, the village's justice on a leaf.” — Written authority and communal memory; original combined trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter −85.

02. Parenthetical narrative notice — “The peepal witness-tree itself is now the target.” — The site of the attack; Chapter −85.

03. Name of a department within the fictional court — “Department for the Administration of Religion in the Mithila State.” — Chapter −85.

04. Allegation in the order — “A centre of tantric malpractice and superstition.” — Chapter −85.

05. Public-interest proposal — “Royal granary.” — Chapter –85.

06. Yaśpati's political vocabulary — “I have brought the power of science and the state.” — Chapter –85.

07. Gaurī's objection — “This tree belongs to the village's memory.” — Chapter –85.

08. Extraordinary condition of the test — “If there truly is some power.” — Chapter –85.

09. Phulesarī's recognition of unequal risk — “If we lose, the tree will be cut.” — Chapter –85.

10. Link between generations — “The hand of her eight-year-old daughter Sāvitrī.” — Chapter –85.

11. Sāvitrī's reported experience — “Someone is crying near the peepal.” — Chapter –85.

12. First physical intervention — “The first axe struck the root.” — Chapter –85.

13. The unusual voice — “Stop.” — Chapter –85.

14. Description through negation — “Neither a woman's, nor a man's.” — Chapter –85.

15. Indeterminate form of the figure — “Trembling between smoke and light.” — Chapter –85.

16. Burhba's ethical self-identification — “I am a witness.” — Chapter –85.

17. Resistance to religious classification — “I am not a god.” — Chapter –85.

18. Distinction between witness and tree — “I am older than this tree.” — Chapter –85.

19. The Āmil's immediate order — “Put down the axe.” — Chapter –85.

20. The Āmil's claim to discernment — “I know how to distinguish illusion from truth.” — Chapter –85.

21. Exposure of Yaśpati's objective — “Not for this tree, but for the land of the leatherworkers' settlement.” — Chapter –85.

22. Unsuccessful command to arrest the fleeing man — “Stop him!” — Chapter –85.

23. Future promise, not completed protection — “I shall recommend placing it under royal protection.” — Chapter –85.

24. Absence within the story's archive — "That report was never found in any archive." — Chapter –85.

25. Burhba's perceptual limit — "I could not see Yaśpati's end." — Chapter –85.

26. Fear of the unknown — "It frightens me." — Chapter –85.

27. Folk remembrance in the closing song — "Paper may tear." — Chapter –85.

Concluding Critical Observation after Chapter –85

The chapter's immediate narrative result is the cessation of the felling. Official protection, the availability of the report, and the fate of the fugitive Yaśpati remain unresolved. The witness-tree's protection derives its meaning from the conflict over folk memory and land rights and cannot be confined to a test of supernatural manifestation. The examination of Chapter –84, "The Silence of the Forest," must continue these unresolved threads.

Critical Section 17 | Original Chapter –84 — The Silence of the Forest

After Yaśpati's flight in Chapter –85, the present chapter investigates his uncertain fate. The search party includes the village headman, young men, and two soldiers belonging to the Āmil. In the forest they discover torn clothing, footprints, shoes, and marks resembling those left by the dragging of a large creature. Yet there is no direct evidence either of Yaśpati's death or of an attack by a crocodile. The finding of objects and definite knowledge of their cause are two different states of affairs.

Burhba acknowledges that his vision stops at the forest's interior. His "no" is not merely a personal admission of ignorance; it delimits the extraordinary powers of witnessing attributed to him in the novel. From the standpoint of Navya-Nyāya, the absence of knowledge cannot legitimately be taken as the absence of the object. Here the novel does not close the mystery with the assistance of an omniscient character. Rather, it opens the mystery through the limitations of its witness.

The search party's decision to abandon its investigation because of fear creates an atmosphere of terror, but it also constitutes an incomplete inquiry when measured against institutional responsibility. No process is shown by which the testimony of the headman, royal soldiers, and members of the community becomes a conclusive official report. The socially recognised ownership of a shoe or a garment is not incontrovertible identification of the individual concerned; nor do the enormous tracks establish the presence of a crocodile or Yaśpati's death.

The forest and the unnamed river operate as a nonhuman chronotope: upon entering this region, the established rules of routes, visibility, and safe movement change. Nevertheless, to treat the environment as a conscious judge would go beyond what the text establishes. The forest's "silence" is the limit of human interpretation.

Gaurī's ethical counter-question makes Burhba's work of preserving names itself an object of criticism. The names of victims must indeed be safeguarded; but to erase the offender's name solely because of hatred may also erase the history of the offence. Remembrance and justice are not synonyms. A comprehensive record must preserve wrongdoing, suffering, and accountability. The older women's recollection of Yaśpati's earlier, more human character does not pardon his offences; it points to the moral complexity of his portrayal.

The narrator exhibits the restricted knowledge of the search party, Gaurī's questions, and Burhba's inability to see. At the end, however, the narrator

speaks of the awakening of an unidentified thing and thereby assumes a position of knowledge beyond that of the characters. This shift of focalization produces a proleptic signal. The conjunction of the fearful, the pathetic, and the wondrous gives the chapter considerable force, although the excessively rapid abandonment of the investigation is a weakness in its causal construction.

The post-chapter discussion, "The Narrative Function of an Unresolved Mystery," is authorial paratext, not an incident in the primary story or independent historical evidence. The final judgment of this analysis is that Yaśpati's fate remains uncertain and Burhba's sight is incomplete. That indeterminacy is a literary achievement, but it leaves the problem of unfulfilled judicial responsibility unresolved.

Critical Section 18 | Original Chapter −83 — Sonmā, the Fisherwoman

A month after Yaśpati's disappearance, goats, buffalo calves, and a young buffalo descended from Kajrī begin to vanish. Dragging marks towards the water resemble the traces associated with the preceding mystery; even so, a definite crocodile attack has not been demonstrated. Burhba recalls the name "the primordial crocodile" from conversations among the old fishing community, although he himself does not know its form. This acknowledgement opens a passage in the narrative towards another community of knowledge.

Gaurī leaves Sāvitrī in Phulesarī's care and travels to Sonmā the fisherwoman's remote hut beside the river. Her journey is more than the movement of a messenger: she mediates access to the knowledge of fishing people, distinct both from scholastic learning and from supernatural memory. Phulesarī's caregiving labour makes the journey possible, but her own point of view is not developed sufficiently.

Sonmā is very old and blind, yet claims that she can "hear" the scent of the peepal in Gaurī's breathing. The crossing of the senses is an experiment in unnatural narration, not a verified proposition of sensory physiology. Burhba's timeless existence as witness and Sonmā's longevity forgotten even by death present two distinct systems of mythical time.

The story nested within Sonmā's account reaches towards water-based folk memory predating written records. Her claim that her ancestors possessed the right to pronounce the names of rivers brings naming, geography, and authority into the same field of inquiry. Yet the claim has the status of an oral assertion within the fiction, without independent confirmation in historical archives. It would also be inaccurate in philosophical terms to treat Naiyāyikas, Mīmāṃsakas, and Brahmins as one identical social category.

Sonmā calls the "primordial crocodile" neither an animal nor a spirit, but "the hunger of forgetting." With this image, the crocodile of the novel's title expands beyond fear of an aquatic creature into a philosophical figure for the perishability of memory. Nevertheless, a moral distinction must be retained between ordinary forgetting and the deliberately organised erasure of records. There is no demonstrated necessary relation between the cessation of the offering custom and the awakening of hunger. Sonmā's suggestion that Yaśpati's hatred awakened an ancient power remains a possible inference, not an incontrovertible event.

Sonmā's central proposition is that being a witness and denying the possibility of forgetting are different undertakings. Rather than waging absolute war against forgetfulness, every name should receive its proper honour before it is forgotten. Gaurī carries this message to Burhba. He admits his hatred of Yaśpati and resolves to seek a balance. The admission marks ethical development in his characterization; whether it produces a practical change still requires testing in subsequent episodes.

In Sonmā's song, nets, fish, and names become symbols of work and remembrance. The net provides a livelihood, while the release of a name proposes an ethic of non-attachment. This produces an interplay of karuṇa, adbhuta, and śānta. Yet the material labour, rights over water, and trade of the fishing community receive extremely brief treatment. When folk knowledge becomes a symbol, the economic world sustaining it risks being obscured.

The post-chapter explanation entitled "Indigenous/Fishing Communities' Traditions of Memory and Brahmanical Encroachment" is paratext, not independent historical verification. Overall, the chapter opens a conflict between memory and forgetting, breaks Burhba's monopoly over knowledge, and creates an inter-traditional conversation through Gaurī. Its weaknesses lie in the untested causal claims of folk belief, the poorly developed social dimensions of Sonmā's life, and the rapid resolution of the witness's self-reproach.

Critical Section 19 | Original Chapter −82 — The First Kabaddi

388. Textual Basis and Narrative Connection

“The First Kabaddi” is the nineteenth independent chapter of the period of prehistory. The original trilogy's table of contents gives page 188 as its opening and page 193 as the opening of the next chapter, −81; its indicated printed range is therefore 188–192. These page references are not a measure of the number of events.

389. Three Years and the Intensification of Crisis

Three years after the meeting with Sonmā the fisherwoman, losses extend beyond livestock to the disappearance of human beings. People who approach the river at night are at greater risk. The transition enlarges the scale of the incidents: lost animals threaten livelihoods, while missing people threaten the community's continued existence. The diminishing presence of fishing, farming, and children's laughter brings together the economic, ecological, and emotional effects of fear. Yet the actual number and names of missing people and the causes of their deaths are unspecified. To identify the disappearances as witnessed crocodile attacks would exceed the evidence.

390. Sāvitrī's Age and the Chronology of Succession

The original text states explicitly that Sāvitrī is now sixteen. The three-year interval and the emergence of a new generation bring the story away from Burhba's circle of long-duration memory into the social education of human lives. In her dream she sees children, the shade of a tree, running, and an unfamiliar word. These images will subsequently take the form of a ritual. The dream here is not a scientifically certain prediction of the future, but an imaginative preliminary design for a possible action within the narrative.

391. A Third Route to Knowledge: Sāvitrī's Proposal

Sonmā taught a balance between remembrance and forgetfulness; Burhba had preserved the names of the dead. Sāvitrī proposes to join the two systems through play. The originality of the proposal lies in transforming a theoretical synthesis into a communal practice that can be repeated. The calling aloud of names and the bodily act of crossing a boundary become parts of one turn. Knowledge here is not merely inherited; it becomes a practice reconstructed by a new generation.

392. Agency and Characterization

Sāvitrī decides to take the first turn herself despite her mother's objections. That choice constitutes narrative agency. She is not passively obeying Burhba's command: she proposes the concept, accepts the risk, and leads a public act. Gaurī is both questioner and cautious guardian, while Phulesarī's presence signifies community participation. Even Burhba, the senior witness, acknowledges that he must learn this new way from Sāvitrī. This intergenerational redistribution of authority is a distinctive achievement of the chapter.

393. Danger and Consent: The Ethical Test of a Ritual

Burhba warns that, should the attempt fail, the primordial crocodile may interpret it as disrespect. The declaration that the community will bear the risk collectively is ethically significant. Yet Sāvitrī is a minor, and the danger is unknown and potentially fatal. The meaning of communal consent therefore requires scrutiny. Gaurī's objection and Sāvitrī's insistence are directly represented, but there is no objective measure of the risk. The narrative's heroic mode does not release criticism from asking whether Sāvitrī is safe.

394. The New-Moon Night: A Chronotope of Performance

The bank of Joṛī Pond, the roots of the peepal, the darkness of the new moon, and the assembled villagers together produce a performance space. The familiar social setting of a game becomes the site of a religious and communal rite. Participants, spectators, cautious observers, and an extraordinary witness are present in the same place. The community does not merely watch: it also acquires the possibility of carrying the ritual forward in subsequent turns.

395. The Rules of a Turn and Their Symbolic Transformation

In ordinary kabaddi, crossing the opposing side's boundary and returning tests bodily skill. In Sāvitrī's altered game, a turn is linked to publicly pronouncing the names of those who have died or been forgotten. The boundary ceases to be merely a line on the field: it signifies life and death, memory and oblivion, fear and courage. “One breath” connects the transience of individual life with the continuity of collective remembrance. The original chapter, however, supplies neither a complete rulebook for the transformed game, nor objective criteria for victory and defeat, nor arrangements for safety. It would be misleading to describe it as a fully elaborated sporting system.

396. The Name of Subhāgī: The Ethics of Selection

The first name called is "Subhāgī." Sāvitrī makes a neglected victim of the flood the centre of public remembrance. Her choice reconnects the game to the preceding chapters' questions about overlooked deaths and the incomplete recording of collective losses. The utterance of a name symbolizes archival justice, but it does not itself rectify the injustice that the deceased suffered. Compensation and responsibility remain open questions after this symbolic victory.

397. Yaśpati's Name: A Resolution of the Earlier Ethical Contradiction

Sāvitrī calls Yaśpati's name second. This is the chapter's most important ethical turn. Burhba had spoken of being unable to preserve that name in the absence of love; Sāvitrī grants even Yaśpati a place in memory, without cancelling accountability for his deeds. She is not declaring victim and perpetrator equally innocent. Rather, she rejects the erasure of a person's existence from history. Remembering Yaśpati can itself become a means of retaining the record of responsibility for his wrongs.

398. The Movement of the Water and the Examination of Evidence

The water moves when Subhāgī's name is called; when Yaśpati's is pronounced, the disturbance becomes more intense. Gaurī warns Sāvitrī to withdraw. Sāvitrī interprets the movement as fear rather than an attack. But movement in water does not by itself establish that the primordial crocodile has heard, reacted emotionally, or even exists. In Navya-Nyāya terms, an observed motion of water is one fact, and inference to its supernatural agent another. The text does not establish a necessary, invariable connection between the two.

399. The Third Address and the Ritual of Balance

Sāvitrī asks the primordial crocodile for patience; she does not deny its existence. Her speech is clearly related to the offering tradition of Sonmā's ancestors. The content of the offering, however, changes: in place of milk, fruit, or flowers comes the respectful articulation of names. This is an ethical reconstruction of religious ritual. Collective remembrance becomes a practice of accommodation and coexistence rather than violent revenge. Nevertheless, no formal acceptance of the proposal by the crocodile is depicted; the account only describes the water gradually becoming calm.

400. Immediate Outcome and the Difference from Long-Term Claims

Once the water has settled, Burhba says that the crocodile has gone to sleep for the night. He himself acknowledges that he does not know whether the effect will last. Immediately afterward, the narrator gives a wider

account of the beginning of a monthly new-moon custom and of an allegedly safer period. These two levels must remain separate. The observable events of the first night are limited; the future effect is reported through narrative summary and folklore. The evidentiary limit conveyed by formulations such as “it is said” matters.

401. Repetition and the Compression of Time

After the extended scene of one new-moon night, many months, generations, and future forms of practice are condensed into a short narrative paragraph. The proportion between story-time and narrative duration changes dramatically. The first experiment is shown as a scene; subsequent repetitions are gathered together through iterative narration. This technique turns a singular founding moment into a long-lived communal tradition. It does not, however, show precisely what occurred on each following new moon; a summary cannot be treated as several independently verified scenes.

402. Foreshadowing and Circular Structure

The narrator refers to the future “timeless kabaddi” of Channā Gāchhī. The prehistory of the novel thereby becomes an account of the origin of a symbol familiar from the main narrative. The story does not merely move forward; it retrospectively reinterprets the reader's future encounter with the text through an event in the past. This is an important hinge in the wider trilogy's recurring relations among names, witnesses, and play. The structural assertion made in the accompanying authorial commentary nonetheless requires independent comparison with the actual later passages of the main volumes before it can be considered finally confirmed.

403. Rasa, Suggestion, and Propriety

Bhayānaka rasa, the fearful, dominates the human disappearances and the nocturnal disturbances of the water. Sāvitrī's willingness to risk herself produces a heroic disposition; the calming of the pond joins wonder to the possibility of tranquillity. The breath, the boundary, and the turn of the game suggest memory's living transmission. But an enduring threat is transformed into resolution very quickly, and the story's tension may consequently dissipate too soon. At points the balance between bodily action and moral instruction tilts towards the latter.

404. Videha Parallel History and the Communal Archive

A ritual in which children repeatedly speak the names of neglected dead people such as Subhāgī is a folk archive of memory. Unlike an official written record, it is re-enacted by the community. Yet oral repetition does not automatically prove every historical assertion conclusively. The

accurate utterance of a name, the person's life history, the circumstances of death, and the question of accountability still require distinct sources. Sāvitrī's game is a powerful technique of remembrance, not a substitute for a fully functioning institution of justice.

405. Social Representation and Gendered Agency

A teenage girl imagines the new ritual; Gaurī and Phulesarī are present at its first public performance. Burhba becomes a learner. This is the arrangement's principal achievement. Yet the later account describes the ritual as being conducted under Burhba's direction. The transition raises the possibility that Sāvitrī's founding role may eventually be redefined under the authority of a male supernatural figure. Criticism must not overlook this tension.

406. The Causal Density of Events

The actual sequence of changes in this chapter comprises three years of losses; Sāvitrī's dream-inspired proposal; discussion of the danger; her decision to take the first turn; the public assembly on the new moon; three invocations—of Subhāgī, Yaśpati, and the primordial crocodile; the water's response; temporary calm; and the institution of a recurring ceremony. Decisions and outcomes are distinguishable within this list. The causal sequence, rather than the number of lines in a song or of verbal predicates, should underlie any defensible appraisal of narrative event-density.

407. Achievement and Limitation

The chapter's central literary achievement is to combine Burhba's disposition to witness, Sonmā's theory of offerings, and Sāvitrī's conception of play in a communal action. The inclusion of Yaśpati's name answers the preceding debate about memory in a meaningful way. The agency of a teenage girl is a persuasive example of the transmission of knowledge across generations. The weakness is that neither the supernatural agent nor the ritual's success is clearly established by the movement of water; its long-term results are narrated too briefly; and the ethics of risk and the practical rules of play remain imprecise. These may be legitimate artistic choices within a mythical narrative, but the distinctions between kinds of evidence remain essential to criticism.

408. Event–Evidence–Judgment

1. Three years of human disappearances and declining livelihoods: the escalation of danger is established within the story, while its cause remains undetermined.

2. Sāvitrī's dream and proposal: a character's thought and choice; the dream does not prove an external future.

3. Discussion of collective risk: an acknowledgement of ethical responsibility; measures for safety are unclear.

4. Calling Subhāgī's name: public restoration of remembrance.

5. Calling Yaśpati's name: refusal to erase the offender's history, not a pardon for wrongdoing.

6. Disturbance of the water: a narrated physical occurrence, not proof that the primordial crocodile has heard or accepted the address.

7. Calming of the water: an immediate experience, not proof of permanent control.

8. Establishment of the monthly game: the birth of a communal tradition; its long-term effects are presented in summary.

9. Foreshadowing of Channā Gāchhī: a proposal of circular structure across the trilogy, open to verification against subsequent passages.

409. Overall Judgment

"The First Kabaddi" is not simply a tale of how a children's game originated. It changes the novel's philosophy of memory from the power of an individual witness into a collective, recurring, embodied performance. Sāvitrī's decisive contribution lies in inventing a social act between the preservation of memory and the acknowledgment of forgetting. Yet the synthesis is not unassailable proof of an irrational miracle; it is a mythical, communal assurance. The novel's vision of justice can be considered fully developed only when the concrete histories of oppressed lives and their questions of accountability are preserved alongside the renewed pronunciation of names.

The original chapter, its closing song, and its post-chapter commentary have been examined as distinct evidentiary levels.

Next in sequence: Original Chapter –81 — The Shadow of the Invasion.

Critical Section 20 | Original Chapter −81 — The Shadow of the Invasion

Textual Basis and Scope of the Review

"The Shadow of the Invasion" is the twentieth independent chapter of the period of prehistory. In the table of contents of the combined original trilogy, Chapter −81 begins on page 193 and Chapter −80 on page 197; its indicated printed range is therefore 193–196. This ratio is not a measure of actual narrative event-density. The present review tests the narrated events against this distinction; it does not count the historical claims of authorial commentary as occurrences in the story itself.

From the Previous Chapter's Ritual to Political Catastrophe

In Chapter −82, the new-moon kabaddi devised by Sāvitrī became a communal practice of preserving names. The beginning of Chapter −81 reports that for twenty years this ceremony has been part of ordinary life: losses of livestock ceased, fear of the distant river weakened, and children made the game part of their shared lives. The immediate danger, however, differs from the possible hunger of the primordial crocodile. Here the threat is armed human violence, political uncertainty, and the fear of refugees. The chapter tests whether the system established earlier has any value in a new kind of emergency. The return of the ritual is consequently not mere repetition; its function changes.

A Leap of Twenty Years and Generational Succession

The original text states that Sāvitrī is now thirty-six and that her daughter Indumatī is twenty. Sāvitrī was sixteen in Chapter −82. Arithmetically, these dates place the beginning of her motherhood at a very early age, but the text does not specify the circumstances of Indumatī's birth. It would therefore be unwarranted to pronounce the chronology intrinsically impossible or defective without qualification. What matters here is that the ritual, sustained over two decades, has passed from mother to daughter. The succession of ordinary human generations offers a tangible measure against Burhba's memory of twelve hundred years. The temporal leap effectively extends the story, though much of the internal social history of those twenty years is condensed into summary.

The Opening Proverb and the Suggestion of Resistance amid Fear

The chapter's proverb, "A shadow growing larger does not mean fear must grow larger," distinguishes the visible scale of a threat from its real effect. Hoofbeats, clouds of dust, and the breathless speech of refugees make a great invasion seem imminent. Later, however, a band of wandering

soldiers reaches the village rather than the principal army. “Shadow” thus also indicates the suspected magnitude of the attack. The proverb announces an ethic of courage at the outset, and the reader expects the events to confirm it. The relation between this prior moral declaration and the development of less predictable events warrants examination.

News Brought by a Refugee: The Status of Testimony

The first refugee cries, “Turkish army!” and collapses at the village meeting place. His report mentions the flight of the king of Simraungarh, the movement of elephants and horses, and burning villages. Within the story this is the alarmed speech of a refugee, perhaps relying upon both personal observation and reports heard from others; it is not an immediately and independently verified royal dispatch. Its social effect is real nonetheless: villagers divide between flight and remaining where they are. The arrival of information and the reactions it produces are different events. The narrator dramatizes the man's collapse but does not develop the origins of his information, the route he travelled, or the limits of his firsthand observation. A complete test of the reliability of his testimony therefore remains outstanding.

A Geography of Fear: The Army and the “Crocodile's Territory”

As the invasion is feared, some villagers propose fleeing into the southern forest, a region earlier avoided as the “crocodile's territory.” The choice creates a comparative geography of fear. A human-made threat of military violence makes a previously dreaded natural and mythical danger appear momentarily less severe. That does not prove the forest is safe: threatened people are comparing different risks. The village, peepal, leatherworkers' settlement, southern forest, and main royal road furnish a spatial system of uncertain distances. Their respective functions matter for explaining the possible movement of soldiers, but the text supplies no complete map of the routes.

The Limits of Burhba's Foresight: Possible Realism

Burhba explicitly says that his witness's sight cannot clearly discern the future course of human warfare. This restates, in another form, the limitation encountered in Chapter –84 when his vision stopped before the unknown forest. Here the limitation concerns not merely invisible objects but unpredictable human decisions. Burhba supposes that a great army will have little interest in a small, poor village unless that village stands upon its route. This is a tentative appraisal of military behaviour, not certain knowledge of the future. In the event, a wandering detachment, rather than the main army, comes near the settlement. The relation between

Burhba's estimate and the narrated outcome therefore retains a measure of uncertainty.

The Transfer of Agency during a Crisis

Burhba advises that those able to flee should be allowed to go, but that secure places must be found for the old, the sick, and children. The significant point is that the witness's speech now encourages human organisation rather than direct supernatural intervention. The chapter's task is not to await a hero's miracle, but to arrange the distribution of communal resources. This marks progress in the narrative's internal ethics: supernatural counsel acquires value when people actually prepare shelter. Yet the process of political leadership and the gathering of resources in the village receives only compressed treatment.

Organisation in the Leatherworkers' Quarter: A Neglected Historical Capacity

The leatherworkers' quarter organises first, because mutual assistance amid danger is already part of its social experience. Old grain bins are extended beneath the earthen floors of houses to conceal children and elderly people. This is the chapter's most concrete act of practical protection. Alongside speculation about how the military might assess a "poor village," the physical labour of an oppressed community tries to secure the village's real safety. For the perspective of Videha Parallel History, the significance lies in what accounts of dynastic decline habitually omit: the practical knowledge by which ordinary working people give one another shelter. Nevertheless, the text does not name the individual workers or specify the shelter's capacity and arrangements for food.

Gaurī's Herbs and the Care of Refugees

The ageing Gaurī undertakes to care for wounded refugees. Her service establishes a meaningful contrast between the earlier political assault on her medical knowledge through the "witchcraft accusation" and that knowledge's present communal usefulness. An expertise previously targeted as superstition is once more drawn upon in a military emergency. This does not establish the medical efficacy of every herbal intervention; the chapter supplies neither detailed treatment procedures, the kinds of wounds, nor the ultimate condition of each patient. The established event in the story is that Gaurī provides care, not that every wounded person makes a complete recovery.

Indumatī: Hearing, Decision, and the Succession of Women

Indumatī hears Burhba's voice most clearly. In the crisis of war she publicly calls for kabaddi to be held outside its scheduled new-moon night. The

moment is not simply a repetition of Sāvitrī's first game. Earlier Sāvitrī had devised the ritual from a dream; now Indumatī initiates the alteration of an established ritual's temporal rule to meet an emergency. Sāvitrī at once organises the children and young people. But Indumatī's formulation, "Burhba is saying," partially raises the question of whether she acts independently. Is she merely transmitting another's voice, or does she exercise judgment in the emergency? The original text suggests both, without developing her interior reasoning at length.

Breaking the New-Moon Rule: The Transformation of Tradition

In Chapter –82, kabaddi became a commemorative ritual on every new-moon night. Now it is held on another night. The alteration places the social purpose of the custom above the rigidity of its calendar. Breaking an inherited rule does not necessarily empty a practice of its power; the community discovers a new use for it under exceptional circumstances. This is an important adaptation from the standpoint of collective performance. The text, however, does not explicitly say that the old requirement to call the names of the dead is followed on this occasion. The children chiefly repeat "Kabaddi, kabaddi." One therefore cannot assert that this scene reproduces the entire original form of the name-preserving turn.

Collective Play: Constructing the Spectatorship of War

Lamps by the peepal, the children's fearless voices, running feet, and repetition produce a public spectacle. The soldiers are not participants in the game; they become outside spectators. Its success now depends upon how they respond. From the standpoint of performance-based narration, the reversal is dense with meaning: a community powerless before armed men influences their judgment through a public form of its own making. Indumatī and Sāvitrī organise, the children construct the spectacle, Burhba advises, and the soldiers observe. The right to speak and the agency to act are distributed among different figures.

The Commander's Conclusion: The Actual Cause of the Military Decision

The wandering soldiers approach the village intending to plunder. Seeing the children at play, their commander reasons that there is nothing worth looting and no reason to waste time. He orders his men onward. The directly narrated cause is the commander's practical decision, not a demonstrated supernatural protective force belonging to kabaddi. The performance changes his estimate of possible gain and resistance; as an account of social psychology this is a plausible mechanism. The narrator,

however, supplies the enemy's mental appraisal, rather than a complete picture of the commander's political or military reasoning.

A Critical Examination of the Causal Sequence

The subject is the avoidance of an attack on the village. The proposition to be established is that the soldiers withdrew because of kabaddi. The directly presented ground is the commander's decision, after seeing the game, that looting the village would bring no profit. Thus the story does offer a causal relation between the spectacle and withdrawal; it does not demonstrate the universal concomitance required to establish that a supernatural power of remembering names turned the soldiers away. Other conditions are conceivable: their fatigue, a wish to rejoin the main army, the apparent lack of valuables, or a mistaken estimate of resistance. The literary success of an episode and proof of its wondrous efficacy are not identical. The analytical apparatus of Navya-Nyāya is useful precisely for retaining this distinction.

The Ethical Limit of the Ritual: Children at Risk

The game creates an image of fearlessness, yet gathering children in public before armed soldiers involves a serious problem of safety. The original text offers no risk assessment: the soldiers see the game and leave peacefully. Had they decided otherwise, the group playing in the open might have been the most vulnerable. A favourable result alone cannot therefore make the decision an unassailable model of communal defence. The tension between literary heroism and risk-conscious protective action is pronounced. In this respect the underground shelter built by the leatherworkers' quarter is a more direct provision for safety.

The Theory of Memory: From Naming the Dead to Protecting the Living

After the incident, Burhba tells Indumatī that remembering names can also save the living. This extends the earlier ritual's metaphysical significance. In Chapter −82, recognition of the dead and the forgotten was central; here the primary benefit is communal confidence and visible steadiness before a threat. Yet the scene itself does not show the names of dead people being spoken, and the soldiers' withdrawal is more directly associated with the children's fearless performance. Burhba's interpretation adds a wider meaning to the action after the event. The distinction is crucial: a character's subsequent moral proposition, the narrator's account of what happened, and the soldiers' behaviour belong to different evidentiary levels.

The Fall of Simraungarh: Separating History from Fiction

During the following week, news arrives that the kingdom at Simraungarh has fallen. The original post-chapter commentary associates the background with the Karnata rulers of the fourteenth century and the attacks of the Sultanate. Historical studies discuss Hari Singh Dev's departure from Simraungarh and the broader Tughlaq military intervention around 1324–25; differences among sources concerning the precise sequence and individual details must be respected. The episode in which wandering soldiers see the children's game and move on is consequently a literary invention, not a documented historical event. The broad historical setting and the credibility of a particular village scene require separate appraisal.

Narrator, Focalization, and the Distribution of Information

At first the narrator summarizes twenty years of communal history. The refugee's warning then gives way to Burhba's estimate, the preparations in the leatherworkers' quarter, and the soldiers' mental decision. In particular, the sight of playing children appears from the soldiers' viewpoint as either "madness" or evidence that there is nothing worth stealing. For a moment focalization shifts from the village to the outsiders. The reader learns the reason for their decision, while the children do not themselves know what they have saved. The resulting dramatic irony contributes to the narrative's effect.

Duration: A Historical Summary and the Scene of One Night

Twenty years of social change are compressed into a few lines. The alarm of an evening and night, the gathering, and the approach of soldiers are presented in relatively extended detail. News of the political collapse arrives in another summary the following week. Thus the movement is summary → scene → summary. Within a great political transition, a small and uncertain military encounter becomes the dramatic centre. Gérard Genette's account of narrative duration is useful here, but the text does not determine the hour of each refugee's movement or every action by the soldiers; a critic must not introduce an invented timetable.

Recurrence: Kabaddi, Shadow, Name, and Fear

Kabaddi first appeared as a founding ceremony in Chapter –82; it returns here with another aim. Even "name" changes its function, moving from remembrance of the dead towards the morale of the living. "Shadow" becomes an image of fear's expansion: news of hoofbeats and clouds of dust makes the approaching threat seem greater than the small military group that arrives. These repetitions therefore perform new work. Nevertheless,

the closing proverb and Burhba's moral commentary reiterate the same lesson in fearlessness and somewhat slow the narrative.

Social Polyphony and Absent Experiences

Some villagers want to flee; others refuse to abandon their homes. Refugees speak in the voice of fear; leatherworkers undertake protective action; Gaurī provides care; Burhba concedes his uncertainty about the future; and soldiers calculate their advantage. These positions offer the seeds of a rich collective polyphony. Yet the families wishing to leave, the results of displacement, and the own voices of those concealed in shelters do not receive independent development. The women's work is narrated, but their distinct fears about the soldiers' arrival rarely become sustained dialogue.

Indian Poetics: Heroic, Fearful, Pathetic, and Tranquil Modes

Hoofbeats, refugees' cries, and dust clouds build an atmosphere of bhayānaka. The organisation of the leatherworkers' quarter and the courage of Indumatī and Sāvitrī suggest vīra. Care given to wounded refugees adds a subdued dimension of karuṇa. Relief and tranquillity follow the soldiers' withdrawal, only for the news of the kingdom's fall the next week to disturb their apparent permanence. Through suggestion, the shared breath of the game becomes the rhythm of collective survival. On the test of aucitya, however, it remains necessary to ask whether the depiction of children's exposure to danger is made plausible merely by the strength of its moral symbolism.

Environmental Narration: The Fear of the Forest and the Fear of War

In the earlier crisis of the primordial crocodile, river and forest were places of livelihood and unknown force. Here that same forest becomes a possible refuge from military danger. The physical meaning of an environment is not fixed; its use changes with social power and violence. Fear of water and fear of war are not interchangeable. The attempt to calm the possible hunger of a nonhuman crocodile through moral confidence belongs to one register; the soldiers' motive for plunder depends upon an identifiable human economic decision. Maintaining the distinction allows environmental and political narrative to retain their separate explanatory ranges.

Narrative Credibility: Evaluating the Victory

It is possible to accept, as a literary premise, that a group of children playing kabaddi without fear changes the soldiers' outlook. Yet the claim that every member of a violent raiding party would immediately withdraw because of that sight remains questionable. Is this a skilful deception by

the villagers, the result of the detachment's fatigue, or mere coincidence? The narrator gives a human causal explanation in the form of the commander's judgment that nothing is to be gained. There is nevertheless a small dramatic leap between the desire to plunder and the rapid inference that the settlement contains nothing worth taking. Proportionate criticism is more appropriate than either categorical rejection of the event or insistence upon its flawless realism.

Separate Account of Event, Evidence, and Result

1. A twenty-year interval: narrative summary of the ritual's persistence, not separate verification of each monthly occasion.

2. The refugee's military news: an actual effect of fear on the community, though the entire army's movement is not independently established at that moment.

3. The leatherworkers' shelter-building: an explicitly narrated action of human protection; the number of people sheltered is unspecified.

4. Gaurī's care: an attempt at treatment; successful medical outcomes are not narrated in detail.

5. Indumatī's exceptional announcement: an adaptation of the ritual's temporal rules to a new emergency.

6. The children's kabaddi: influences the soldiers' perception; supernatural efficacy remains unproved.

7. The commander's order to withdraw: the direct cause of the immediate cessation of the threat of looting.

8. Burhba's philosophy of memory: an interpretation given after the event, not the entire causal explanation.

9. News of the fall of Simraungarh: a political transition within the story-world; precise historical details require independent sources.

Final Judgment and Connection with the Next Chapter

"The Shadow of the Invasion" transforms a previous ceremony of preserving cultural memory into an experiment in civic self-protection. Indumatī's initiative, Sāvitrī's organisation, the shelter-building labour of the leatherworkers' settlement, and Gaurī's work of healing move the chapter towards communal autonomy. Four limitations must be recorded alongside this achievement: the partly abbreviated causal logic of the soldiers' quick decision to leave; the risks faced by children; the compressed representation of unequal experiences within the village; and the limitations of linking ancient political developments to an imagined local

incident. Most significant is that, even while the news announces the collapse of a dynasty, the living villagers continue their work, remembrance, and mutual protection. The history of the state reaches an ending, but the history of the community begins anew. Chapter –80, "The First Line of the Song," takes this further into the question of how communal voices are made into literature.

Critical Section 21 | Original Chapter −80 — The First Line of the Song

Textual Basis, Chapter Limits, and Critical Questions

“The First Line of the Song” is the twenty-first independent chapter of the prehistory. In the table of contents of the combined original trilogy, this chapter begins on page 197 and the following chapter, −79, “The Turn of Forgiveness,” on page 201. Its indicated printed range is therefore 197–200. The chapter's central concern is not the original institution of the ritual, but its passage from oral remembrance into writing and a possible archive. The tests of criticism here concern the right to write a story, the transition from hearing to inscription, and the ethical responsibility of the person who preserves a written version.

From the Previous War Emergency to the Preservation of Literature

Chapter −81 had signalled a new political era through news of Simraungarh's fall and the military danger that reached the village. Chapter −80 does not immediately narrate further violence. Instead, it establishes an atmosphere in which disorder has gradually subsided and a new courtly interest in literature has emerged. Thus the narrative moves from protecting bodies to protecting cultural memory. During the previous emergency, inhabitants of the leatherworkers' quarter hid children and the elderly; here Haripati proposes to write down folk stories that might otherwise be forgotten. Both acts are protective, but one preserves lives and the other stories. The critical question is how faithfully the voices of those who protected lives can enter the written history that follows.

Historical Background: The Narrator's Claim and External History

The novel uses the coming of the Oinwar dynasty to link political stability, courtly patronage, and an asserted flowering of Maithili literature. This is an authorial proposition about history. A single chapter does not establish every fact concerning a particular royal court, the sequence of dates, patronage arrangements, or the growth of literary expression in Maithili. In particular, the historical geography and chronological identification of “the royal courts of Darbhanga and the surrounding region” require examination against independent historical sources. Literary criticism should first identify the description's narrative function: the larger change in ruling power provides the social circumstances for the arrival of an itinerant poet in the village. The artistic validity of that connection and its documentary validity as history belong to different categories.

Haripati's Fictional Status: Avoiding Confusion with a Historical Name

The commentary following the original chapter expressly states that Haripati does not stand for a particular historical individual. He represents a broader literary tendency. It would therefore be improper to treat him as a documented poet, search for the supposed historical manuscript he is said to have written, or cite his words as archival testimony. Within the story, he is a travelling writer who gathers folk songs and oral accounts while seeking patronage. Through this invented circumstance, several impulses can be combined in a single character: desire for courtly support, affection for the vernacular, the wish to collect stories, and the possible preservation of literature for the future. Precisely because he is representative, his individual biography may remain underdeveloped. That is a limitation of characterization accompanying his usefulness as a literary figure.

The Itinerant Poet's Outlook: The Motive for Collecting

Haripati hopes to obtain patronage at court, yet believes that the real strength of Maithili is found in the speech of ordinary villagers. The contradiction creates a possibility of social movement within the story: he approaches the seat of power in search of a livelihood, while drawing the material of his writing from communities beyond its walls. The choice between learned and popular forms is therefore not simply a matter of taste. It concerns resources and prestige as well. Whether the court will support him remains unknown. It is equally unclear whether putting the stories into writing will raise chiefly his own status or benefit the communities who supplied them. The narrator's confidence in his "honesty" encourages trust, but the effects of his collecting upon working and marginalized people require a separate examination.

Indumatī's Identity: The Time Marker Twenty Years Later

Indumatī was twenty in the preceding Chapter –81; she is forty in the present chapter. The numbers indicate that twenty years have elapsed between the two chapters. She has become a principal custodian of the new-moon ritual after her mother Sāvitrī. The phrase "after her mother Sāvitrī" does not, by itself, prove Sāvitrī's death; it may also describe the succession or transfer of a responsibility. In Indumatī's mature position, the cultural authority of a woman within the community appears firmly established. Yet the process of this transformation is chiefly contained in a short narrative introduction rather than developed scene by scene. Two decades of local conflict, teaching, and practice remain behind that compact statement.

The Listening Writer's Astonishment and the Three Foundational Questions

Haripati is astonished by three matters: Burhba's witness-tree, the primordial crocodile's hunger for forgetting, and kabaddi played while calling the names of the dead. Recalling them is not merely a device to remind the reader of prior chapters. It dramatizes how an outsider might respond to them. What generations of villagers have experienced as an ordinary, continuing practice becomes, in the eyes of the visiting writer, material for an extraordinary epic. The distinction contains the risk of cultural appropriation: the community lives its experience, while the collector sees it as a literary object. Haripati's proposal must be assessed in the light of Indumatī's objection.

Indumatī's Question: Who May Write "Our" Story?

Indumatī's assertion, "This story belongs to all of us," forms the ethical centre of the chapter. The pronoun "us" rejects the exclusive ownership of the narrative by either Burhba or Haripati and establishes the village, its settlements, and shared experience as the narrative's source. Haripati may become a collector of stories, but not the creator of the lives from which they emerged. This separation makes the categories of creative labour visible: undergoing an event, telling it orally, listening, selecting, transcribing, and later interpreting are different acts. The text places Indumatī's objection before the reader, but it does not determine systematic rules for copyright or textual ownership, permission to make copies, communal review, or conditions of use. "This story belongs to all of us" is thus not merely a sentiment. It is an active claim to archival justice.

Oral Memory and Written Preservation

Haripati argues that an oral account may change from generation to generation, while a written version can persist into the distant future. There is a genuine possibility in that proposition: a stable manuscript gives readers a basis for returning to the same words and making comparisons. Yet alteration in oral tradition is not always corruption; a community adapts its account to new circumstances and needs. Nor is writing immune to the destruction of paper or palm leaf, a writer's selective decisions, errors in copying, control over access, or prohibition. The simple opposition oral tradition = instability and writing = immortality is not a demonstrated law. The contradiction makes this chapter more interesting when Haripati subsequently decides against publishing his manuscript.

Burhba's Warning: Ornament of Respect or Justice?

Through Indumatī, Burhba warns Haripati that to adorn the suffering of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Subhāgī, Ratnā, and Mālatī in the decorative language of the royal court would inflict injustice again. Language in this argument is not merely a medium of aesthetic experimentation. It is an ethical instrument of social representation. The determining distinction is whether poetry makes human pain into material for artistic enjoyment or gives the sufferers' voices respectful expression. It does not follow that courtly or ornate language must invariably be unjust. The deeper issue concerns the speaker's right to speak, the ownership of the story, and the preservation of its living social context.

Three Stages of Mediation: Burhba, Indumatī, and Haripati

Burhba's condition does not reach Haripati directly: Indumatī carries the message. Haripati addresses his reply towards Burhba's peepal, but does not himself see the witness. The narrative exchange therefore unfolds through mediation rather than face-to-face contact. Burhba's extraordinary status, Indumatī's social authority, and Haripati's ability to write perform separate functions. Particularly significant is that the beginning of the written tradition depends upon a woman's intervention. In the closing scene, however, the individual poet's pen becomes the prominent object. The redistribution of authority between a woman responsible for an inherited body of knowledge and the male holder of written prestige is a central question for criticism.

The Palm-Leaf Manuscript and the Scope of the Word “Paper”

Haripati takes out a palm-leaf manuscript and a writing implement. Earlier the text speaks generally of making a record “on paper.” These two references describe materially different media. Does the narrative use “paper” broadly as a term for written inscription, or has the physical medium become inconsistent? Before identifying a conclusive error, one must also consider ordinary Maithili usage in which “setting down on paper” may be figurative. Nevertheless, because the longevity, copying, and transmission of manuscripts are central to the chapter, greater consistency about palm leaf, paper, and bound manuscripts would have been useful.

The First Line: A Distinction from the Original Novel's Actual Opening

Haripati begins his written account with “There was a tree, there was a pond.” It would be wrong to present this as the verbatim opening of Chapter –100 of the actual trilogy. It is the beginning of an imagined prior manuscript constructed inside the story. Its compact grouping of the tree, pond, and servant preserving names compresses the longer narrative into a memorable formula. In the process, the complex social history of

the original incidents becomes the seed of a story. A question of selection arises: the individual voices of victims such as Hulāsā and Jīvantī do not appear in the first line, while Burhba's witnessing action stands near its centre. A decision about whose experience will lead the future narrative is already being made in its opening words.

Three Months of Creative Labour: Writing, Erasing, and Rewriting

Haripati stays in the village for three months, listens to the elders, writes, erases, and writes again. This is an important sequence of real changes in the chapter. Writing does not spring fully formed from sudden divine inspiration; it requires repeated attempts to recognize and render communal speech. Recording an oral narrative is not a mechanical transcription. It is the outcome of editorial decisions. Yet the original text does not show which passages were changed, what conflicting accounts were encountered, or whether Indumatī or Burhba had a chance to examine the manuscript. The three-month process is compressed into summary. The labour of composition is present, while the concrete chain of evidence for textual revision is missing.

Patronage at Court and the Decision Not to Show the Manuscript

At the outset, Haripati travels between villages while looking for a place under courtly patronage. After three months, he decides not to present the manuscript at court. His explanation is, "The court will not understand it." This is a considerable alteration in his values: despite his desire for patronage, he refuses to seek the court's approval for the stories. How the livelihood problem introduced at the start is resolved, however, remains unclear. Nor has the text examined the universal proposition that no reader or patron at court could understand the folk narrative. In the story, distance from the seat of power becomes a moral withdrawal, while the material impediments to earning a living recede for narrative convenience.

Preserved for a Disciple, Withheld from Publication

Haripati considers passing the manuscript to a disciple, while requiring that it remain unpublished until the world is ready to "listen and understand." His earlier argument for the public protective value of writing now becomes a theory of restricted access. If a story originating within a community remains sealed in the private succession of one poet's disciples, its ownership is once again concentrated in a few hands. Protection can become excessive control. Who will decide when the world is ready: the disciple, the poet's descendants, Burhba, or the community itself? The chapter gives no answer. An unpublished manuscript is a

possible means of future preservation; it is not an established institution of public record.

"A Written Story Never Dies": Examining the Necessary Connection

Burhba says that a story written honestly never dies completely, even if no one reads the manuscript for centuries. This is an inspiring statement of faith in the preservation of memory, but not an independently demonstrated physical or social law. The manuscript may be destroyed; its inheritor may die; the script may become illegible; the language may change; or access may be prohibited. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, if written form is made the means and permanent survival the proposed result, no necessary concomitance between them has been established. The statement's literary truth lies in collective hope. Its status as an empirical claim would require further proof. This criticism does not dismiss the narrative's intention; rather, it distinguishes a moral promise from the material means of fulfilling it.

Self-Reference: A Future Computer Screen

Having quoted Haripati's first line, the narrator speaks of another writer in the future who will compose a story called A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles (A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles) on a computer screen instead of paper. The present book thus imagines a precursor to its own creation. This is a powerful example of self-reflexive narration: the reader understands that Haripati's manuscript belongs to a story within the novel, while the project of a contemporary writer is anticipated within that same narrative. Yet the boundary between narrative levels can be said to be crossed in the strict technical sense of metalepsis only where characters from different levels intervene in one another's actions. Merely announcing a future author does not, by itself, constitute full metalepsis. Its principal functions here are prolepsis across a very long period and the book's interpretation of its own existence.

The Narrator's Knowledge and Haripati's Ignorance

The narrator says that Haripati knew nothing of the distant future awaiting his first line. In this respect, the narrator possesses more information than the character and offers the reader a forward-looking signal. Haripati is occupied with the problems of making his manuscript; the reader glimpses the outline of a future literary work. Such unequal information produces dramatic irony and a sense of historical breadth. It also risks predetermining the later work's literary value: announcing the success of a text's survival in advance may influence the reader's independent assessment. The method of self-authorization requires recognition in critical analysis.

The Collective Song and Plural Authorship

The central proposition of the closing song is that there is "not one author." One person begins; ten others add to the composition; a hundred sing it. Through this progression, literature becomes not a single genius's act but a process of collective accumulation. Yet within the narrative the person who actually writes the manuscript is Haripati. The community supplies the stories and performs an indirect role in evaluating their language. The song proclaims the plurality of labour, while the scene of writing concentrates on the pen of one man. This is more than a simple inconsistency: it invites criticism of the social process through which collective knowledge becomes individual literary prestige.

A Dispute over Language: Popular Speech and "High" Literature

Haripati prefers the Maithili spoken by villagers to the Sanskrit-inflected poetry of the court. Burhba likewise requires respect for the voices of those who suffered. This is an important literary assertion of people's right to their language. Yet the relationship between a standard or courtly language and the vernacular cannot invariably be reduced to a strict opposition between oppressors and oppressed. The relationship between literary form and social rights is more complicated. Selecting, transcribing, spelling, and editing popular speech all involve questions of who has authority and for whom the writing is intended. The chapter establishes an inspiring principle but does not elaborate a complete ethical method of language editing.

Women's Rights in the Story and Male Prestige in the Archive

Indumatī, now forty, is the leading keeper of the ritual. She raises the first objection to an outsider's writing of the story and conveys Burhba's conditions. Haripati ultimately makes the manuscript. Under this arrangement, the experiences, protective labour, and communal claims of women do not become the most prominent visible elements of written history; the moment of the male poet's writing is more fully dramatized. Yet it would also be mistaken to treat Indumatī as a passive emblem of consent. Her hesitation and questioning regulate the ethical legitimacy of the entire undertaking. The achievement is the establishment of a woman's claim as a challenge; the limitation is the lack of any clear rule guaranteeing her authority over the manuscript's preservation.

Neglected Lives and the Recurrence of Names

Burhba again names Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Subhāgī, Ratnā, and Mālatī. The list carries the unfinished struggles of earlier chapters into the present resolve to write. Naming is a minimum act of representation. The story does not yet show how the individuals' speech, conflicts, private

relationships, and potentially contradictory testimony will be preserved in the manuscript. In particular, the impossibility or difficulty of obtaining consent from the dead intensifies the writer's responsibility to exercise judgment. A list of names begins a record of people's history; it does not establish a complete biography of each of them.

Story, Archive, and the Social Distinction between Forms of Evidence

Oral testimony can be a source for history, and palm leaf can become a medium for recording it. Yet a written copy may differ from the original statement because the collector selects incidents, changes language, and determines sequence. Haripati's three months of work constitute a meaningful human effort, but the account contains no independent copy, communal verification of the text, or comparison of contradictory versions. In Navya-Nyāya, the reliability of verbal testimony is related to speaker, intention, transmission, and subject matter; transcription alone does not produce true knowledge automatically. The relationship between author, community, and reader therefore requires explicit attention in any critical practice associated with Videha Parallel History.

Narrative Duration: Months, Years, and Centuries

At the beginning, a long political transition—from the fall of Simraungarh to the emergence of a new literary climate—is conveyed in compressed summary. Haripati's arrival and conversations with Indumatī take the form of developed scenes. His three months of writing and revision are again gathered into a short sequence of sentences. The reference to a future writer at a computer crosses several centuries. Narrative duration thus moves from summary → scene → summary → prolepsis. This disproportion between great political developments, summarized briefly, and a single evening of manuscript writing, depicted as decisive, reveals the priorities of the novel's telling: political history is the background, while the first line of a people's story becomes the principal scene.

Focalization and the Unequal Distribution of Knowledge

Through an expansive third-person perspective, the narrator describes Oinwar rule, the village's reaction, and a future author. Haripati's amazement, Indumatī's doubts, and Burhba's warning reach the reader through dialogue. Indumatī's reservations receive only a brief glimpse of interiority; Haripati's honesty is established through the narrator's evaluation. This control of focalization increases the appearance of Haripati's reliability: readers accept his “deep honesty” through the narrating voice. The collection of stories could have become more

genuinely polyphonic had opposing voices from other villagers been given independent opportunities to challenge his proposal.

A New Narrative Function for Repetition

The peepal, Burhba, names, kabaddi, and the list of neglected dead people have appeared in many previous chapters. Here the same symbols acquire a new function: names once recited as part of a rite may become material for a written text. The change of function constitutes genuine narrative progression. The injunction to "preserve names" does not remain another philosophical sermon; it attempts to become a social institution through palm leaf, pen, disciple, and the decision to withhold publication. But the attempt is incomplete. No public institution of communal textual ownership comes into being. Its limitations will require examination against later episodes involving manuscripts.

Rasa, Suggestion, and Oblique Expression in the Song

In the closing song, the sequence of the first singer, ten collaborators, and a hundred people singing establishes a rising rhythm of oral collectivity. An individual beginning becomes a plural outcome. The line "The song never dies" suggests symbolic victory over time, even though the story admits that manuscripts can be lost. Aesthetic hope and historical insecurity exist together in this contradiction. The remembered names of the neglected dead provide a background of pathos; the acceptance of preservation as a duty gives rise to an aspiration towards tranquillity; and the future self-reference produces a sense of wonder. Nevertheless, the song repeats the moral principle already stated, and much of its additional poetic force lies in the rhythm and the structure of collective utterance.

Post-Chapter Commentary: The Limit of Explanatory Paratext

A commentary entitled "The Oinwar Dynasty and the Golden Age of Maithili Literature" describes Haripati as a figure for a cultural tendency, rather than a specific historical poet. This is important paratextual information for understanding the character. The commentary also introduces connections with Videha magazine and the parallel literary movement. But this clarification of authorial intention does not independently verify the historical events dramatized in the novel. The evaluative term "golden age" demands critical attention: whose literature received prestige at court; which oral traditions remained outside the archive; and did the gains of literary advancement reach every community?

Event–Evidence–Outcome Register

1. The subsiding of disorder and the narrative of Oinwar government: a broad narrative background; the external history requires separate investigation.

2. Haripati's arrival in the village: an expressly narrated event; he is a fictional representative, not an identified historical person.

3. Indumatī's account of the ritual: public transmission of oral knowledge.

4. Haripati's proposal to write: a personal desire to create a record; a question about rights of ownership emerges.

5. Indumatī's "all of us" objection: an explicit ethical claim to communal ownership.

6. Burhba's condition that ordinary language be used: an ethical constraint upon representation; accessible language is not itself proof of the truth of every statement.

7. Haripati's production of the first line on palm leaf: a directly narrated scene of inscription.

8. Three months of revisions: a summary of the collector's real labour; the different manuscript versions are not described.

9. The decision not to present the manuscript at court: a change in the character's values; the outcome for his livelihood is unknown.

10. The proposal to preserve it with a disciple: a plan for future transmission, not the establishment of open public access.

11. The reference to a future author writing on a computer: self-reflexive prolepsis, not evidence of a historical palm-leaf document.

12. The communal song: a declaration of collective authorship; no enforceable rule of ownership is established.

Register of Quotations Checked against the Original Chapter

1. Opening proverb: "There is no single author; the village itself is the creator." — A pledge of collective creation.

2. Indumatī: "This story belongs to all of us." — The question of narrative ownership.

3. Haripati: "I want to preserve it." — The collector's declared intention.

4. Burhba: "If it is to be written, let it be written in ordinary language." — A condition of representation.

5. Haripati's first line: "There was a tree, there was a pond." — The beginning of an imagined proto-manuscript within the story.

6. Haripati: "The court will not understand it." — The conflict between protection and access.

7. Closing song: "A song sung by all together never dies." — The symbolic claim of communal immortality.

These excerpts were compared with the story portion or closing song of original Chapter –80. The printed range 197–200 refers to the chapter as a whole; a separate printed page has not been assigned to each particular quotation.

Impartial Overall Judgment

The chief achievement of "The First Line of the Song" is to move the preservation of memory beyond the limits of a supernatural witness and an oral rite into the question of written records. Indumatī's objection gives the work its fundamental question: "Whose story is this?" Burhba's condition that ordinary language be retained establishes an ethic for the representation of marginalized communities. The three months spent revising show the worth of creative labour. The reference to a future writer at a computer attempts to furnish the novel with a self-conscious account of its own making. But the excessive confidence in the immortality of a written object; the restriction of a communal narrative to private succession through one disciple; the categorical rejection of courtly readers; and the undefined written rights of its woman custodian remain substantive critical limitations. Through these tensions, the chapter becomes not merely a celebration of idealized folk culture but the unresolved centre of a question about evidence and archives that can be supported by the text. "There is no single author" becomes a just conclusion only when the community is granted an active part in determining the story's meaning, revisions, use, and inheritance.

Source and the Next Connection

The primary source is Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, complete trilogy, Part 0, original Chapter –80, "The First Line of the Song," combined original manuscript, printed pages 197–200 according to its contents. The post-chapter commentary "The Oinwar Dynasty and the Golden Age of Maithili Literature" is paratext, not independent historical evidence. The next chapter, –79, "The Turn of Forgiveness," moves from the right to record a memory to the social practice of forgiveness.

Critical Section 22 | Original Chapter −79 — The Turn of Forgiveness

Textual Basis, Method of Examination, and Central Question

"The Turn of Forgiveness" is the twenty-second independent chapter of the pre-narrative period. The original novel's contents place the opening of Chapter −79 at page 201 and the next chapter, −78, "Outside the Genealogical Register," at page 205; the indicated printed range is therefore 201–204. The examination concentrates on setting, time, recurrence, the character's choices, and the outcome of the narrative. Its central question is whether someone who did not personally commit an ancestor's injustice can nevertheless acknowledge a responsibility arising from benefits inherited through that injustice, and what right of forgiveness such a public admission gives the community. To answer, ethical, legal, emotional, and narrative evidence must remain distinguishable.

From the Previous Chapter's Manuscript to a Living Communal Ritual

Chapter −80 attempted to convert oral remembrance into written form under Indumatī's leadership. Haripati composed a manuscript but decided to withhold it from publication. Chapter −79 opens an altogether different situation. Memory is now neither merely the words preserved in a manuscript nor the nocturnal invocation of the dead. It becomes a social arrangement through which a living individual places the inherited moral burden of his ancestors before the community. The preceding chapter asked, "Who will write the story?" This one asks, "Who will acknowledge the story truthfully and accept responsibility?" That shift constitutes a definite dramatic advance within the novel's continuing philosophy of remembrance.

Forty-five Years of Story Time: Generational Sequence

The chapter begins by announcing an interval of forty-five years. After Indumatī, responsibility for the ritual passes to her daughter Śāradā, and after Śāradā to Vasundharā, now forty. This establishes a female line of cultural succession: Sāvitrī–Indumatī–Śāradā–Vasundharā. The narrative does not give a separate historical date from which to derive a precise calendar year for the interval. Invention of exact birth dates would be inappropriate. Equally, the statement that Raghuvīr is Pratāpsen's grandson must be handled carefully in relation to the extended earlier chronology. An aged grandson is possible; the dates required for a verified genealogy of the historical sort are not available here.

The Opening Proverb: From Touch to the Right of Return

The chapter's proverb reads: "In kabaddi, give even the person you have touched a turn to return." Ordinary physical touch becomes the possibility of ethical return. Earlier "touch" concerned the commemoration of dead names and the crises of the present; now it signifies the community's response to a living descendant of a family involved in historical wrongdoing. Forgiveness is proposed not as passive forgetting but as a regulated process of re-entry. Nevertheless, the moral value of forgiveness is announced in advance through the proverb, directing the reader's expectations towards reconciliation. The instruction of the song should not replace an independent evaluation of the dramatic scene.

At the Gate of the Leatherworkers' Settlement: A Stage of Social Boundaries

Raghuvīr first comes not to the peepal but to the gate of the leatherworkers' settlement. This choice of place is highly significant. His grandfather's name revives the memory of oppression there. His arrival is not an ordinary social visit: the descendant of a family associated with exploitation asks entry into the injured community. Yet the gate scene is brief. Which family sees him first, who decides the question of safety, and whether descendants of the people directly harmed in the land conflict are present receive little development. The gate is a powerful symbol; the material detail of communal deliberation is compressed.

Raghuvīr's Bodily Portrait: Fading Power, Surviving Prestige

Extremely old, Raghuvīr arrives leaning on a staff. His expensive but torn and soiled garments create a visible contrast between a history of privileged property and present distress. His body is exhausted, his voice shakes, and his eyes fill with tears. The established image of inherited dominance is reversed: a Thakur's grandson stands pleading at the gate of the leatherworkers' settlement. Yet age and tears alone are not incontrovertible evidence of ethical change. They are dramatic means of inviting sympathy across a history of privilege. The narrative conveys a sense of sincerity in his words, but its decisive test lies in restitution of land and consequences for the community.

"The Offence Was Not Mine": Separating Personal Guilt

Raghuvīr says the offence was not his, although he carries the burden of his grandfather's sin. This introduces the essential moral distinction between person and lineage. An individual should not be judged guilty of an ancestor's deed merely by birth. At the same time, the present beneficiary of wealth acquired through injustice may face responsibilities

connected with that inheritance. Both elements are present in Raghuvīr's initial plea: his denial of personal commission and his recognition of the ethical effects of inherited advantage. The more precise critical reading is not inherited criminal guilt but a possible duty of restitution arising from succession.

Family Privilege and the Profits of Injustice: The Material Basis for Restitution

Raghuvīr acknowledges that his family's property and comforts are connected with injustices committed against the leatherworkers' settlement. Forgiveness is therefore not merely an emotional purification; it becomes a public questioning of the origins of property. An internal textual tension remains, however. Chapter –87 stated that the community's land rights were re-entered in the official record. Here Raghuvīr proposes to return part of land wrongfully acquired by his grandfather. Other plots may have been involved, or a later acquisition may have occurred, but the intervening history is not explained in this chapter. The relation between the earlier victory of re-entry and the present need for restitution remains open. To label the connection an established contradiction would be premature, but clarification is warranted.

Vasundharā's Cautious Question: Judicial Discernment

Vasundharā does not immediately accept the visitor. Remembering the painful associations of Pratāpsen's name, she asks why he has come. The reaction acknowledges the injured community's right to exercise judgment. His old age does not free Raghuvīr from questioning; nor does his lineage require that he automatically be humiliated. His purpose is examined. Vasundharā seeks Burhba's counsel, showing that the decision is not immediately made by a single person. Still, the question remains whether Burhba's advice becomes a substitute for formal discussion throughout the settlement. Greater independent space for Vasundharā's reasoning would further strengthen the autonomy of women's leadership.

Burhba Reinterprets His Philosophy of Memory

Burhba accepts that he is only now beginning to understand the limits of preserving dead people's names. The work of memory must also allow the living to correct their own stories. This is another stage in his long transformation since his water burial in Chapter –90. Chapter –84 posed the dilemma of preserving the wrongdoer's name; Chapter –83 brought Sonmā's lesson of patience; Chapter –82 publicly pronounced Yaśpati's name; Chapter –79 now presents a descendant's acknowledgment before the community. This is functional recurrence rather than mere repetition.

But Burhba's speech still assumes considerable ethical authority, and its relation to communal consent remains open to questioning.

The Right to Request Forgiveness and the Right to Receive It

Raghuvīr suggests that he lacks even the right to ask for forgiveness because he did not commit the offence himself. Shame and ethical uncertainty coexist in that statement. Seeking forgiveness may be an admission of wrong or an attempt to repair a relationship; granting it, however, depends on the consent of the victim or the relevant community of successors. The absence of personal culpability does not necessarily prevent an ethical request for reconciliation, although it does exclude automatic legal responsibility for an ancestor's criminal act. In this scene forgiveness is not granted as an automatic absolution; a new rule is devised for admitting a person into communal memory. Admission and pardon must therefore be distinguished.

The Public New-Moon Assembly and the Witnesses to the Act

At night, old people, women, and children assemble by the peepal. Raghuvīr sits with help from a descendant of Phulesarī. The gathering combines public witnesses across generations, while an unnamed member of the oppressed community physically supports the descendant of the once-dominant family. The act has considerable symbolic force: a hereditary beneficiary of power now depends bodily on the care of those associated with earlier injury. Yet the helper remains nameless even as Raghuvīr's name later enters a proverb. This raises a problem of representation. Attendance does not, by itself, establish unanimity; public witnessing differs from a formally established communal agreement.

A New Rule for the Turn: From Calling a Name to Becoming One

Vasundharā announces that Raghuvīr will not call anybody's name today: he will himself "become a name." The meaning of kabaddi changes again. Previously the player invoked the dead; now the living penitent becomes the subject of public memory. The invention is striking, but the mechanics of the game remain unclear. Raghuvīr is elderly and physically weakened. Does he actually play a bodily turn, or is his turn purely symbolic? The narrative does not specify. The ambiguity comes from giving ethical "turn-taking" priority over the previously established practical rules of the game.

Rewriting a Name: From Pratāpsen's Grandson to "The One Who Returned"

Vasundharā does not erase the fact that Raghuvīr is Pratāpsen's grandson. She adds to it a new deed: he has come to acknowledge his family's

wrongdoing. This is an attempt to redescribe communal identity, not obliterate memory. To remember Raghuvīr alongside the dead, such as Sukhdev and Hulāsā, is not to equate guilt, suffering, or social position. The later expression "Raghuvīr, who returned" shows the long passage from an individual's confession to collective meaning-making. Whether that condensed expression might eventually marginalize a detailed account of the ancestral offence remains an open critical question.

The Proposal to Return Part of the Land: Not Buying Pardon

Raghuvīr offers to return part of the land wrongfully gained by his grandfather, explicitly saying that this is not an attempt to buy forgiveness. The self-imposed limitation gives the passage ethical seriousness. Repentance is not simply an act of weeping; it tries to address the material benefits inherited from wrong and its continuing consequences. But how much constitutes "part," how much was wrongfully acquired, which families possessed the original rights, and whether restitution will be communal or individual are all left unspecified. Consequently, the emotional acceptance of an apology and the accomplishment of full restitution remain separate questions.

Burhba's Incomplete Touch: A Limited Supernatural Ethical Act

Burhba descends from the peepal and attempts to place his hand on the living Raghuvīr's forehead. His hand stops one finger's breadth above the body. This is perhaps the chapter's most concentrated symbolic moment. The extraordinary witness expresses ethical nearness while remaining unable to touch human flesh. The unsuccessful touch can also figure the distance between sympathy and actual restitution. Burhba's blessing may inspire responsibility, but cannot substitute for the social action of transferring land. The scene displays a degree of consistency in the rules governing the novel's magical-realistic world.

Distinguishing the Ethical Status of Grandfather and Grandson

Burhba remembers Pratāpsen's name with sorrow, but determines to preserve Raghuvīr's with respect. This is not an acquittal of an entire lineage. Two generations of a single family can occupy distinct ethical positions in remembrance. Such differentiation is one of the work's conceptual achievements. Yet whether recording the grandfather's name "with sorrow" sufficiently preserves the real historical details of the crime depends upon the testimony of many victims. Burhba's distinction is an ethical statement within the narrative, not a comprehensive verified history.

Weeping and Self-Purification: The Limits of Emotional Evidence

Raghuvīr's tears are interpreted as the lifting of a burden carried for years. This emotional release is effective in the structure of rasa, but tears are neither experimental proof of complete ethical transformation nor an automatic indication that every affected member of the community has forgiven him. The novel creates an intense moment of karuṇa. Criticism must nevertheless separate the experience of compassion from a judicial verdict. Burhba's and Vasundharā's sympathy, together with the attempted return of land, lend the character credibility; they do not extinguish the questions of personal and communal accountability.

Transfer of the Partition Deed: Another Incarnation of Written Evidence

The following morning Raghuvīr hands the land-partition document to Vasundharā in the presence of village witnesses. Since Chapter –80's palm-leaf record of popular history, the function of written material has changed. It is no longer merely a repository of memories but a possible instrument of land rights. Yet the document's title is given without its legal structure. Signatures, plots, measurements, revenue entries, registration, and the procedure of actual possession are not supplied. Handing over the paper is a directly narrated event; full legal transfer of title would be an additional, unsupported inference. Symbolic restitution and unfinished institutional justice therefore coexist.

Individual Gift or Communal Land Right?

The document is handed to Vasundharā, while Raghuvīr speaks of returning land to "this settlement." Giving a person a document and restoring an entire community's collective entitlement are not the same legal transaction. Vasundharā is the custodian of the ritual. The text does not clearly establish her authority to hold land in communal trust or distribute it on behalf of the affected households. This is an important critical gap. To strengthen the portrayal of social justice, the separate consent of affected families, distribution of benefits, and subsequent possession of plots would have been useful dramatic material.

Inheritance of Property and Crime: A Navya-Nyāya Examination

Raghuvīr's lineage does not establish that he personally committed his grandfather's crimes; Pratāpsen's wrongdoing was narrated in previous chapters. The present pakṣa is inherited property in Raghuvīr's possession. The sādhya is the unjust acquisition of some portion of it. The hetu is the family's connection to earlier profit and Raghuvīr's confession. His confession is significant testimony, not definitive proof that every

particular parcel is unlawfully held. No necessary concomitance is established for the proposition “all land belonging to Pratāpsen's grandson was acquired unjustly.” Conversely, the absence of Raghuvīr's personal criminal guilt does not remove the ethical need to examine his present benefits. Separating pakṣa, sādhya, hetu, and possible qualifications clarifies the subtle difference between inheriting culpability and inheriting advantage.

Remorse, Acknowledgment, Restitution, Reconciliation, and Forgiveness

Five states require different names. Raghuvīr's tears and shame amount to an emotional claim of remorse. His recognition of his grandfather's wrong is an acknowledgment. The proposal and document transfer are an attempt at restitution. Honouring his name at the village gathering is an act of social re-entry. But the original text presents no separate, explicit procedure through which the injured party declares complete forgiveness. To treat the whole process as a final absolution would exceed the evidence. The maturity of Burhba's witnessing consists in keeping these states together without supposing that every problem disappears in a single moment of tears.

Balancing Sympathy with Justice

An old, weary person asking pardon readily becomes a centre of the reader's compassion. But the long economic losses sustained by the leatherworkers' families do not receive an equally immediate dramatic presentation. The aesthetic centre can consequently shift towards Raghuvīr's moral redemption. Social justice asks not only, “How much does the descendant of a privileged family suffer?” but also, “How much of the land, livelihood, property, and standing of the injured people has been restored?” The chapter's merit lies in Raghuvīr's insistence that he cannot purchase forgiveness; its limitation is the insufficient examination of outcomes from the victims' standpoint.

Four Generations of Women: Authority over Remembrance and Decision

Sāvitrī devised the ritual; Indumatī inherited its care and discovered new applications; Śāradā and Vasundharā kept it alive in the subsequent generations. Memory is thus transmitted actively by women rather than merely along a male scholastic lineage. Vasundharā changes a rule, permitting Raghuvīr himself to become a name. Without Burhba's counsel she might not have done so, but Vasundharā remains the visible organiser of the proceedings. That achievement of female agency should be

acknowledged along with its limit: the persistent influence of Burhba's authoritative, male-coded, supernatural interpretation.

Phulesarī's Descendant: Visible Labour, Invisible Name

As Raghuvīr sits beside the peepal he relies on a descendant of Phulesarī for support. The helper's name is never provided. In a story centrally devoted to preserving every name, a person who performs necessary assistance remains anonymous. That is a meaningful tension. The phrase "Phulesarī's descendant" may be intended to demonstrate familial continuity, but the absence of an independent name denies the individual full standing as a character. A method of social history should especially note the persons whose work is shown but whose names remain unwritten.

Scene and Summary: Unequal Narrative Time

The opening lines compress forty-five years. Raghuvīr's arrival, the public exchanges, and the new-moon turn are expanded into scenes. The transfer of the written document the following morning is brief. His return home a month later and the news of his death six months later receive even less narrated space. Generational change is summarised, public confession is extended, and the end of a life is rapidly passed over. Emotional acknowledgment consequently dominates the reader's memory, while the social duration required for possession and distribution of land remains largely out of view. This management of duration is both an artistic strength and a limitation of social representation.

Recurrence and Change of Function: From Dead Names to a Living Name

The name-preserving kabaddi developed in Chapter −82 around the memory of the dead Subhāgī and the disputed Yaśpati. In −81 it served living communal courage. In −79 another turn is performed under a new rule. Three meanings emerge from these returns: resistance to oblivion, collective unity under threat, and the procedure of ethical re-entry. A single ritual acquires fresh functions in distinct circumstances. This is a particular literary achievement. Yet if every difficult political or social problem is solved through a turn of kabaddi, the ritual risks becoming an excessively convenient narrative device. The concrete act involving the land document partly guards against that danger here.

The Narrator's Voice: Directing Compassion and Preserving Uncertainty

The third-person narrator directs sympathy through Raghuvīr's weakened body, sorrow, and confession. Vasundharā's initial caution is also recorded, preserving a contrary perspective briefly. Burhba's reaction then becomes

the principal vehicle of moral resolution. At the end, the narrator asserts that a village proverb arose, but does not provide multiple independent versions of that communal speech. Narratorial certainty and the characters' emotional experiences occupy different evidentiary positions. Maintaining this distance in criticism does not deny the scene's compassion; it makes its construction legible.

The Many Meanings of "Returning" within the Story

Raghuvīr's return is not simply a bodily journey back to the village. He turns from a family's oppressive past towards confronting the truth; communal remembrance receives him under a new designation; after his death his identity returns in a saying. The word "return" accommodates movement, remorse, an attempt at restitution, and folkloric re-entry. Nevertheless, its gentle resonance must not conceal the different temporal scale of the victims' losses. Raghuvīr expresses a desire for restitution in one night; damage to the leatherworkers' settlement may have persisted through generations.

Rasa, Suggestion, and Propriety

Raghuvīr's trembling voice and tears are major determinants of karuṇa. Vasundharā's cautious questioning establishes a necessary distance from easy compassion. The declaration of returning land suggests heroic self-command or generosity; the finger's breadth separating Burhba's hand from the forehead becomes a delicate image of the marvellous; the final village song raises an aspiration towards communal śānta. The title "The Turn of Forgiveness" connects the metaphor of touching and returning with ethical action. The difficulty of aucitya, or propriety, lies in the rapid emotional consummation: a grave history of property dispossession may appear to have been resolved in a single evening's ritual.

Videha Parallel History: Lineage Names and an Excluded Community

The chapter's historical significance lies in redirecting a genealogy of privileged descent towards ethical history. Raghuvīr's lineage brings not inherited honour but a question about an ancestor's injustice to the gate of the oppressed settlement. The leatherworkers' oral memory gives an ethical hearing before an official paper intervenes. Yet the parallel-history perspective must identify the risk that the remorse of the privileged family becomes recorded while individual injured households remain nameless. The traditions of Hulāsā, Sukhdev, and Phulesarī are mentioned, but whose land was taken and whose claims are actually restored remains part of the unwritten economic history.

The Document, Witnessing, and the Link to "Outside the Genealogical Register"

The partition deed is the chapter's decisive object. Chapter –78, "Outside the Genealogical Register," raises the issue of written lineage and social exclusion. Their connection is significant: here a document becomes a possible instrument of land rights; there a document may govern whose name is admitted into or excluded from recognised social memory. Criticism should not prejudge the full next chapter merely from its title. The present chapter nevertheless plants questions concerning property and records whose development can be tested in the ensuing text.

Event-Based Evidence Table from the Original

Event	Textually established transformation	Unproved or unresolved aspect
Forty-five years of ritual succession	Line of Indumatī, Śāradā, and Vasundharā	Independent calendar years unspecified
Raghuvīr arrives in the leatherworkers' quarter	A descendant of an elite lineage comes to question an injured community	No proof of his personal offence
Acknowledgment of inherited injustice	Statement of ethical responsibility	No full record of property holdings
Vasundharā consults Burhba	Amendment to the rules of communal remembrance	Formal agreement from every family not shown
New-moon turn-taking	A living penitent is given a place in memory	Rules of actual physical play remain unclear
Promise to return land	Proposal for restitution	Extent of all unjust gain is unknown
Transfer of the partition deed next morning	Direct handover of a document	Legal registration and possession unresolved
Burhba's incomplete touch	Supernatural ethical closeness	No actual bodily contact
News of death after returning home	Summary of the end of a life	Disputes over remaining property unspecified
Proverb "To return like Raghuvīr"	New designation in folk memory	The original crime has not been fully described publicly

Verified Indicators of Evidence in the Original Text

1. Opening proverb — the rule of "the turn of forgiveness": allowing someone touched to return.

2. Raghuvīr — "I am Pratāpsen Thakur's grandson": acknowledgment of descent.

3. Vasundharā — "Why have you come?": the injured community's right to question.

4. Raghuvīr — "The offence was not mine": denial of personal culpability.

5. Burhba — "Give the living an opportunity to correct their own story": modification of the philosophy of remembrance.

6. Vasundharā — "Today you will yourself become a name": the ritual's new rule.

7. Raghuvīr — "This cannot buy forgiveness": the limitation of restitution.

8. Burhba — "From today I shall hold your name with respect": a separate moral designation.

9. Narrator — "He handed the partition deed to Vasundharā": the transfer of a written object.

10. Final proverb — "To return like Raghuvīr": a new name within popular memory.

These indicators have been matched with phrases from the original narrative of Chapter –79. They are drawn from different passages, and no unverified fine-grained page numbers are supplied.

Overall Critical Conclusion

The distinctive achievement of "The Turn of Forgiveness" is to place in one continuous sequence the preservation of victims' names, the refusal to erase the offender's name, a living descendant's acknowledgment, and the partial return of property gained through injustice. Vasundharā is not only the guardian of a ritual; she proposes a new ethical rule. Burhba's incomplete touch gives delicate expression to the witness's limited power and the necessity of human action. The land document links compassion to material restitution and keeps the novel from mere sentimentality. Yet full forgiveness cannot be proclaimed when only some land is discussed, actual possession and benefit distribution are obscure, the relation to earlier restoration of title is unclear, and individual voices of injured families are compressed. The literary judgment is conditionally favourable: forgiveness is not revenge, but neither truth, evidence, responsibility, nor restitution can be replaced by a song of remembrance.

Source and Transition

Primary source: Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, complete Maithili trilogy, Part 0, original Chapter –79, "The Turn of Forgiveness," combined manuscript, contents-based printed pages 201–204. The preceding original Maithili-manuscript entry indicates 806 word units and 56.5 per cent action-indicative paragraphs; that indicator must not be confused with a verified event count. The separate commentary, "Collective Guilt and Intergenerational Forgiveness," is paratext, not an

additional narrative event or proof of total pardon. Next: Chapter –78, “Outside the Genealogical Register,” examining genealogical power, missing names, and the evidence of social exclusion.

Critical Section 23 | Original Chapter −78 — Outside the Genealogical Register

Textual Basis and the Central Critical Question

"Outside the Genealogical Register" is the twenty-third independent chapter of the pre-narrative period. The original episode begins with a general account of the purpose of the written pañjī, then follows Yādavānand Jhā's interruption of a journey, Vasundharā's hospitality, the new-moon game, Burhba's message, and the writing of names for three hours into a private notebook. No revision of an official genealogical register is narrated. The critical question is this: when a register designed to preserve the genealogies of certain designated communities comes to be treated as the standard for the historical memory of society as a whole, where are the lives outside its declared scope recorded? Criticism must acknowledge the novel's social challenge while retaining the limits of its evidence.

The Opening Proverb: Unequal Authority of Paper and Earth

"He whose name is absent from the pañjī is not thereby outside the village": the opening sentence differentiates recognition by name from social existence. Absence from a written register does not abolish someone's actual life or relation to the land. Its second half, "The one whom paper left out was embraced by the earth," transforms the earth into a figure of living relationships and collective labour. But a subtle distinction matters: the poetic assertion that the earth accepts a person is not equivalent to legal protection of land rights. Raghuvīr's transfer of a partition document in the preceding chapter demonstrated that written records can themselves assist in restoring rights. The opposition between "paper" and "earth" should therefore be read as criticism of an incomplete archive, not a simple rejection of records.

The Alleged Social Scope of the Pañjī System

The novel presents the pañjī as a selected genealogical record of lineage, gotra, ancestral origin, marriage relationships, and family standing. The preserved pedigrees of Brahmin and Karṇa-Kāyastha lineages are contrasted with the nonappearance of leatherworkers, fishing people, and other marginalized communities. Yet the stated function of a particular genealogical system is not the same as that of a universal census of Mithila. A fair criticism asks what happens when the record of selected classes becomes the only prestigious standard of social memory, thereby distributing recognition unequally. "Not named in this genealogical register" does not entail "never named in any historical record

whatsoever." An independent study of the precise history of the pañjī system would be necessary to establish the latter sort of claim.

The Pañjī Assembly and the Institutional Setting of Authority

The narrator describes periodic genealogical conferences at which record-keepers enter new marriages, inspect earlier entries, and decide questions of family status. The assembly itself does not appear as a fully dramatized scene. Its operations are presented as narrative background. It would therefore be wrong to claim that the opinions of all the record-keepers, particular decisions, or counterarguments were directly observed in this chapter. The background nevertheless explains Yādavānand's institutional training. He trusts the system that he serves; his experience in the village reveals limits to what has traditionally been recognized as knowledge. The narrator's background exposition and the direct dialogue must be kept at separate evidentiary levels.

An Interrupted Journey: The Causal Work of a Sick Horse

Yādavānand travels back from a genealogical conference in the direction of Garh Nārikela, but his horse suddenly becomes ill. He must spend a night in the village meeting place. This small incident permits two otherwise distinct worlds of knowledge to meet. Had the horse remained well, no reason is provided for his stopping here. Chance acts as a narrative cause. A succession of further favourable coincidences—scarcity of food, Vasundharā's help, and the fact that it is the new-moon night—then lends the sequence a highly purposeful shape. The rapid arrangement allows a major moral change in a short chapter, but somewhat diminishes the natural probability of the circumstances.

The Year after Famine: Scarce Food and the Meaning of Hospitality

Food remains insufficient in the village after a famine. The Brahmin quarter offers shelter to the visiting genealogist, while Vasundharā sends milk and fruit from her own household. Resource inequality therefore involves more than caste observance or ritual: the actual availability of food in a difficult year also matters. Vasundharā's aid is offered without demand for return, but unqualified glorification should be avoided. Sharing household milk and fruit under scarcity may carry a cost to the giver. The novel does not state the economic position of her household or the quantity of provisions available to its children. The generosity of the scene is evident, but the familial cost of women's labour, animal care, production, and hospitality remains concealed.

"Pure" Milk and the Irony of Caste Conditioning

Yādavānand praises the milk's taste and "purity." His face becomes uneasy when he learns that it comes from the leatherworkers' settlement. The scene is one of the chapter's most effective miniature dramatic arrangements. Sensory experience first yields a positive judgment about the milk; subsequent knowledge of the producer's caste imposes discomfort upon that same experience. In the language of Navya-Nyāya, tasting and socially acquired verbal classification are distinct cognitive situations. Pleasant, "pure" taste proves nothing about the producer's caste ranking; nor does knowledge of origin itself change the milk's material qualities. The scene is a strong counterexample to caste prejudice. But the genealogist's mental reversal is extremely rapid: unease almost immediately becomes curiosity.

The Headman's Hesitation: Mediating Authority and Fear

The headman hesitates before disclosing the milk's source. Later, reluctantly, he takes Yādavānand to observe the peepal ritual, fearing that a prominent genealogist's interest in a supposedly "low" practice might be dangerous. This hesitation shows local caste conventions and anxiety about outside Brahmanical authority. The headman is not a neutral interpreter; he tries to regulate the public visibility of the community's ritual. Yet his fear remains an inference. Yādavānand has not actually threatened violence. The headman's anxiety can be understood as a social experience without converting it into proof of hostile intent on the part of this particular visitor.

The New-Moon Coincidence and the Witnessing of a Performance

That very night is a new moon: a convenient but effective narrative coincidence. The visiting record-keeper encounters not just a verbal account of the ritual but the public practice itself. Children play, names are called, and Vasundharā adds brief life stories. An oft-repeated rite now becomes a demonstration before an unfamiliar observer. Had the villagers merely said, "Our names are absent from your register," the encounter would have remained a claim. Instead he directly sees and hears communal acts of remembrance. But what he sees is the performance of a ritual; the accuracy of each biographical fact pronounced within it remains a distinct question.

The Sequence of Names and the Expansion of Social History

Ratnā, Somar, Mālatī, Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Subhāgī, and Gaurī enter Vasundharā's public narration. They are more than a simple list; they reselect and join the memories of preceding chapters. Whereas the genealogical register preserves names to follow family descent, Vasundharā

gives significance to lives through experiences of injustice, work, death, and remembrance. Nevertheless, a list of names is not yet a complete history. Relationships, dates, circumstances of birth and death, social conditions, and potentially contrary accounts are also needed. The novel says that she adds a short story to each name, without fully re-presenting every life here. The compression assists readers who remember the earlier chapters but limits independent scrutiny for new readers.

Vasundharā's Knowledge and Authority Established by Questioning

Yādavānand asks, "Whose names are all these?" Vasundharā answers that they belong to their ancestors and to people whose lives were deprived of justice. The formally trained genealogist asks, and a woman of the leatherworkers' settlement supplies the relevant life histories. The customary hierarchy of knowledge is inverted. Vasundharā is not merely a generous host or organiser of a ceremony. She becomes a specialist in preserving names, relationships, and concise narratives. Her practice is oral and collective rather than a personal written treatise. Scholastically certified and experientially grounded knowledge are not necessarily mutually exclusive; they involve different materials and duties of verification.

Yādavānand's Self-Doubt: A Cognitive Event in the Plot

Yādavānand admits that his register contains thousands of names but not a single name from this settlement, and that the question had never previously occurred to him. The narrative makes this admission an event of intellectual change. The horse's illness, drinking the milk, and watching kabaddi are external preparations for the change in understanding. "I do not know the answer" is not the automatic defeat of scholarship but the beginning of an inquiry into its boundaries. Still, the genealogist does not develop a full defence of the original purposes and structure of his institution. A more extended debate might have explored more rigorously how the legitimate function of selected genealogies differs from the failure to preserve wider social history.

Burhba's Extraordinary Address: Changing the Rules of Hearing

The original text establishes that Burhba's voice can generally be heard only by Vasundharā and descendants of Sāvitrī. This night he opens his voice to Yādavānand for the first time, uncertain of the result. The exception expands the rules of this magical-realistic narrative world. It serves a clear dramatic function: the newcomer receives Burhba's philosophy of memory directly. But under what conditions can the previously inherited restriction upon hearing be changed? The text describes the attempt as an "experiment," without specifying the

mechanism. The scene is effective as literature while leaving a question about the consistency of its supernatural system.

Burhba's Two Archives: Lineage Standing and Love of Truth

Burhba tells the genealogist that the pañjī preserves family lineage and social standing, whereas his own memory preserves truth and love. He considers both necessary. The statement is critical without calling for the destruction of official genealogies; it demands recognition of their limited scope. Yet to turn the distinction between "lineage" and "truth" into an absolute moral binary would imply that accurate family entries are not true, or that all memories guarded through affection must be accurate. Earlier chapters have shown that Burhba's hatred of Yaśpati impeded his willingness to preserve that name. His own claim must also remain open to critical examination.

The Birth of a Private Notebook: The Official System Remains Unchanged

The next morning Yādavānand takes a small blank notebook out of his bag. He explicitly says that it is not an official pañjī and may never become one. This determines the limit of the proposed "shadow register." It inaugurates a private, alternative record; it is not an actual institutional reform of a caste-delimited genealogical system. Personal conviction may be an initial condition for reform, but there is no evidence here of changed regulations, centres of recording, public access, or formal recognition. The notebook might be useful as a collection of testimony, but its public purpose remains undefined.

Three Hours of Testimony: Oral Expansion and Written Compression

For three hours Vasundharā recites names and relationships across generations; Yādavānand writes each name, relation, and brief narrative. The novel condenses this prolonged act of taking testimony into a handful of sentences. From the standpoint of narrative duration this is important: the labour of prolonged documentation receives less textual space than the genealogist's astonishment and confession. We do not see how errors were corrected, contradictory testimony addressed, dates verified, names distinguished, or ambiguous descent explained. Much of the procedure by which the supposedly preserved information was written remains hidden from the reader.

Blank Paper and a New Beginning in Archival Practice

The blank notebook is not simply another instance of palm-leaf manuscript-making. In Chapter –80 Haripati spent three months collecting stories and writing a literary manuscript; in –78 Yādavānand

spends three hours recording communal genealogical details. The first effort concerned the literary shaping of narrative, the second the registration of names, relationships, and descent. Different rules of evidence are required for each. The novel shows Haripati's revising labour and Yādavānand's immediate writing, but neither passage establishes procedures for public checking, copying, or long-term custody. Blank paper is an image of archival renewal, not an already complete system of social justice. The image gains depth by acknowledging precisely that incompleteness.

Access to the Alternative Register: Who Can Read and Correct It?

Yādavānand promises to honour these names as much as those in the official register for as long as he lives. But he does not say that the notebook will remain in the settlement, be copied, or be open to Vasundharā's descendants. Privately recording knowledge received from a community can return control over it to an individual. Haripati's unpublished manuscript reserved for a disciple raised the same question in Chapter –80; Yādavānand's notebook repeats it in another archival form. Its future custodian is unknown. The novel acknowledges the uncertainty, and that restraint has genuine critical importance.

Reliability of Testimony: Trust, Sources, and Review

As guardian of a public ritual, Vasundharā preserves a tradition of names repeated by participants and listeners through generations. This establishes a socially sustained testimony. Yet proof of particular pedigrees may require checking personal names, parental relationships, periods, places, and marital links. The text says that Yādavānand writes "every name, every relationship, every short story," but shows no investigation of a contested relationship. The notebook is therefore proposed as a faithful transcription of Vasundharā's testimony, not demonstrated as incontrovertible proof of every historical assertion. The simple opposition "oral testimony unreliable; written record reliable" remains unsubstantiated.

Navya-Nyāya: Absence from Records versus Absence from Existence

The pakṣa concerns ancestors of the leatherworkers' settlement; the proposed sādhya concerns their social existence or recognition in memory; and the cited hetu is absence of their names from an official pañjī. It would be a fallacious inference to derive nonexistence of these people from that documentary absence. If the register's subject matter consists of Brahmin and Karṇa-Kāyastha genealogies, the absence of unrelated groups may follow naturally from its defined scope. Yet the social politics of treating this scope as the limit of recognition still demands questioning. Epistemological error is possible in both directions: "not registered,

therefore they never lived," and "repeated in folklore, therefore every detail is true without examination." The novel argues for alternative testimony within the space between these mistakes.

Kinds of Evidence: Perception, Testimony, Inference, and Absence

Yādavānand perceives the milk directly by tasting it and observes the ritual. He receives accounts of ancestors from Vasundharā as verbal testimony. The missing settlement names represent documentary absence. His question, "What sort of justice is this?" belongs to moral inference and normative judgment. The experience of hearing Burhba is a claim of extraordinary perception within the fictional world, not verified testimony for an external historian. These positions should not be collapsed into one. Ethical commitment to truth and methods of factual investigation are companion processes, not identical ones.

A Caution about Qualification: "Pañjī" Is Not One Institution in Every Usage

In this chapter pañjī serves four functions: first, a specific type of lineage-based genealogy; second, in Burhba's speech, a symbol for the memory of Mithila; third, in Yādavānand's notebook, an expanded list of people; and fourth, in the song, an image of social recognition. If every instance is interpreted as a universal public register, the subject of the critique changes without notice. Navya-Nyāya's concern with the avacchedaka, or delimiting condition, helps distinguish the scope of family genealogy, the scope of social history, and the scope of moral recognition. The novel's power lies in confronting these different limits with one another; philosophical rigour requires them to remain distinct.

Women and Labour Enter the Register of Names

Vasundharā calls the names of women such as Ratnā, Mālatī, Subhāgī, and Gaurī alongside memories of Somar, Hulāsā, and Sukhdev. The concluding song particularly raises the exclusion of Dalits, women, and the poor from paper records. But these three categories are not synonyms. A Dalit woman may be poor, yet not all women or poor people share one caste or documentary status. The widening list gives social breadth to the chapter; historical research would still require differentiated evidence regarding caste, gender, occupation, and economic position.

The Woman as Collector and the Man as Writer

Vasundharā recounts genealogies for three hours; Yādavānand transcribes them. The immediate knowledge source is a woman; the likely bearer of recognized written authority is a man. Who will receive credit if a future reader finds the book? Will it be called "Yādavānand Jhā's shadow register"

or "Vasundharā's oral genealogy"? The text supplies no definite title. The issue of authorship returns directly from Chapter –80's encounter between Indumatī and Haripati. By repeating it, the novel applies its question of literary ownership to the writing of history itself.

How Impartial Is Burhba's Memory?

Burhba speaks of "truth and love" as the centre of his record. Yet he previously confessed that hatred made him unwilling to preserve Yaśpati's name. It is therefore unjustified to regard him as an entirely impartial archivist. Love may inspire the selection of names, but it can also produce selection bias. Both the genealogist's lineage restrictions and the witness's affective choices require transparent standards. The importance of an alternative memory system is not merely that it is kinder; it must make possible the public correction of its own errors.

Burhba's First Listener from Outside: The Convenience of a Miracle

The fact that Burhba's voice reaches Yādavānand produces an immediate transformation in the character. Yet the villagers' oral accounts, the genealogist's own experience of caste discomfort, and Vasundharā's ancestral histories had already been presented. If only the supernatural voice persuaded him, the independent force of a marginalized woman's testimony would be reduced. The order of the scenes is therefore crucial: Yādavānand begins questioning the injustice of his archive before hearing Burhba. The marvel is not the sole cause of his transformation, but a symbolic confirmation. Preserving that order protects Vasundharā's authority to know and speak.

The Limits of the Defeat of Caste Prejudice

Yādavānand drinks milk supplied by the settlement, observes the ritual, hears Burhba, and makes an alternative notebook. All these changes are narrated. But there is no developed evidence that his caste-related conduct throughout the rest of his social life has been transformed. Nor do other genealogists, conference participants, or residents of the Brahmin quarter respond within the chapter. Personal insight and the dismantling of an institutional caste system are not the same event. Durable social change might require agreement by other record-keepers, revision of archival procedures, and active participation by excluded communities. Those developments are matters for later textual verification, not achievements already narrated here.

Event Density: External Actions and Changes of Knowledge

The chapter arranges relatively few external actions: the genealogist's journey; the sick horse; his overnight shelter; arrival of the milk; the visit

to the peepal; observation of kabaddi; hearing a voice; opening a blank notebook; and writing for three hours. The cognitive transformation moves from initial caste discomfort towards recognition of the genealogy's limits. The horse's illness causes the entire encounter, Vasundharā's spoken material changes the visitor's questions, and those questions produce the private act of inscription. The chain of events is causally intelligible, although its coincidences are unusually close together.

Duration and Narrative Pace: One Night and Three Hours

The long history of the genealogical system is compressed into a few background sentences; direct conversation expands one night's experience; and three hours of recording names the following morning is narrated briefly. The reader consequently remembers the genealogist's emotional and intellectual disturbance more vividly than the labour of making the register. This unevenness of duration has a clear artistic justification: the principal goal is to open the archival question. Criticism must nevertheless note that the invisibility of verification and record-making limits the realism of the archival process.

Recurrence: Milk, Peepal, Names, and the Changing Work of the Book

The leatherworkers' care for others was present in earlier crises; here milk tests the idea of caste purity. The peepal was originally a place of remembrance, and now becomes a site of the record-keeper's intellectual awakening. Names once called during kabaddi become a written list of relationships. Haripati's literary manuscript gives way to Yādavānand's genealogical notebook. These functional changes make the narrative's repetition productive. But if each new outsider is immediately transformed by the village miracle, the novel risks overusing the same dramatic device.

Rasa, Suggestion, and Social Propriety

The genealogist's unease upon learning the source of the milk brings a brief scene of embarrassment; wonder follows the children's performance, and humility emerges at the end. Karuṇa arises from the memory of excluded lives, while the new archival effort allows an aspiration towards śānta. The suggestion that "paper is limited, earth is vast" contrasts the archive's scope with the greater scope of life. Yet the vastness of the earth does not abolish the need for written evidence. The peepal and new-moon setting are artistically appropriate, while repeated coincidences and an extensive social reassessment within one night compress the character's conflict.

The Archival Ethics of Parallel History

From the perspective of Videha Parallel History, the essential questions concern who has authority over the record, how source communities participate in writing, and whether a supplementary archive can endure. Before Vasundharā's statement becomes "data," her voice and name should remain attached to it. Yādavānand's notebook is a sincere private beginning, but its future is fragile without public copies, open review, an index of name variants, source notes, and community access. The expression "half of memory lies in darkness" is a sharp figure for inequality, not a calculated claim about precisely half the population.

Historical Comparison: The Pañjī System and Authorial Commentary

The post-chapter note, "The Pañjī System and Social Exclusion," discusses historically selective genealogical recording and the author's research into genealogies. It clarifies the chapter's intention but does not verify that Yādavānand was a real historical individual, that his horse fell ill, or that the three-hour transcription took place. The commentary itself declares the character and events fictional. The "shadow register" is accordingly a symbol of an alternative archive created within the story. More precise assertions about dates, places, and procedures in the actual history of genealogical records need independent historical evidence; literary criticism must not fabricate what the text does not provide.

Achievement in Social Sensibility and Limits of Narrative Execution

The chapter makes the problem of selective caste recording visible through three concrete experiences: milk, ritual, and a private notebook. Vasundharā is not simply a giver of alms but an independent keeper of historical testimony. The genealogist admits his ignorance and explicitly refuses to pretend that his private notebook already has official status. Such self-restraint gives the episode ethical maturity. The weaknesses are the lack of independently developed institutional opposition, reactions from other record-keepers, rights over copies of Vasundharā's testimony, revisions to official rules, and similarly affected communities. Burhba's direct address also operates as a device for accelerating personal transformation.

Table of Events, Evidence, and Outcomes

Event	Textually established outcome	Unproved or unresolved aspect
Background of the pañjī assembly	An archival system for selected lineages is described	Actual limits of each historical pañjī require independent examination
Sudden illness of a horse	Reason for spending the night in the village	No external history for the coincidence

Event	Textually established outcome	Unproved or unresolved aspect
Milk and fruit offered by Vasundharā	Hospitality across caste boundaries	Economic cost to the household unknown
Discomfort about the milk's source	The record-keeper's caste conditioning becomes visible	Lasting change of conduct untested
New-moon kabaddi	Public recollection of ancestors' names	No independent documentation of every name
Vasundharā recounts ancestral history	Presentation of oral genealogical information	Disputed connections not independently checked
Yādavānanda's admission	Questions the selected reach of the register	No official correction yet
Burhba's voice	Supernatural experience of testimony for the record-keeper	Detailed mechanism of hearing unexplained
Personal blank book	Beginning of an alternative archive	It does not become an official pañjī
Three hours writing names	Individual transcription with relationships	Copying, accuracy checks, and public access unresolved
Promise to preserve the book	Personal ethical undertaking	Future institution and succession unknown
Closing song	Cultural pledge of inclusive remembrance	Legal and social equality are not automatically established

Verified Evidence Register from the Original

1. “One whose name is not in the pañjī is not outside the village” — opening proverb and distinction concerning existence.

2. “So pure, so delicious!” — initial praise of the milk.

3. “It comes from the leatherworkers' settlement, Panditji” — identification of its social source.

4. “Whose names are all these?” — birth of the archival question.

5. “Our ancestors', Panditji” — Vasundharā's authority of knowledge.

6. “Until today this question had never occurred to me” — the record-keeper's self-doubt.

7. “I do not know the answer” — acknowledgement of the limit of knowledge.

8. “I shall teach you no scripture” — Burhba's announced limit of address.

9. “Both are necessary” — coexistence of two kinds of archives.

10. “This will not be an official pañjī” — the institutional limit of the notebook.

11. “Tell me every name” — invitation to record oral testimony.

12. “For as long as I am alive” — the limited duration of a personal pledge.

13. “Paper is limited, but the earth is vast” — the song's archival figure.

These quotation indicators come from the scene and song in Part 0, Chapter –78. Its contents-based printed range is 205–208; exact page locations of individual utterances are not independently established.

Overall Narratological Judgment

“Outside the Genealogical Register” is a notably effective short narrative about the moral boundaries of archives. A record-keeper's initial caste discomfort, the hearing of names in the new-moon ritual, Burhba's witnessing voice, and Vasundharā's three-hour oral account generate an individual transformation in knowledge. The essential achievement is its argument that socially recognized memory cannot be exhausted by a written archive of privileged lineages; workers and people subjected to injustice have their own family histories. A particularly valuable feature is that the visitor does not falsely claim official recognition for his private record. Yet the transition from individual encounter to reform of a collective institution remains undescribed, as do the supplementary book's source checking, copying, preservation, and communal control. The chapter is a powerful beginning in the pursuit of just memory, not proof of completed archival equality.

Source Note and Transition

Primary source: Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, complete Maithili trilogy, Part 0, original Chapter –78, “Outside the Genealogical Register,” combined Word manuscript, indicated pages 205–208. A separate entry in the original Maithili manuscript is also mentioned. The appended note, “The Pañjī System and Social Exclusion,” is treated as paratext and itself declares the character and events fictional. The next section examines Chapter –77, “Burhba's Silence,” in which Vasundharā's succession and the narrative function of silence come under scrutiny.

Critical Section 24 | Original Chapter −77 — Burhba's Silence

Textual Basis, Actual Chapter Limits, and the Central Question

"Burhba's Silence" is the twenty-fourth independent chapter of the pre-narrative period. Its principal sequence comprises a ten-year interval; Kauśalyā's inheritance of the ritual; the weakening of Burhba's voice; silence on a new-moon night; confusion over names; Godāvarī's question; a communal rite of witnessing; the return of light and voice; and the institution of the annual "Remembrance of Burhba." The appended commentary, "The Exhaustion of Caregivers and the Need for Reciprocity," is authorial paratext, not independent clinical evidence. The central critical question is whether an institution of memory can remain sustainable when the life of the witness himself is obscured from communal remembrance.

The Previous Chapter's "Shadow Register" and the Witness's Crisis

In Chapter −78 Yādavānand Jhā transcribed Vasundharā's ancestral names into a private notebook. This gave the community a possible alternative written basis for preserving its history. Chapter −77 returns to the vulnerability of Burhba's own remembrance. The juxtaposition is narratively meaningful: after the community acquires another medium of inscription, its original extraordinary witness appears to be in danger. Yet the text does not show Godāvarī using the notebook in the solution that follows. The shadow register and the remembrance of Burhba may be understood as complementary, but their formal institutional combination is not established by the scene.

A Ten-Year Leap: The Person's Diminution and the Institution's Apparent Stability

The opening states that ten years have passed. Vasundharā's daughter Kauśalyā assumes the ritual's responsibilities, while village life continues in its customary rhythms. A long social period is compressed into a brief summary. Once the inherited practice appears stable, Burhba's exhaustion becomes more startling. The chapter does not explain precisely when or under what circumstances Kauśalyā succeeded her mother, or whether Vasundharā remains alive. The outcome of succession is clear, the process is not. The narrative condenses the intervening history in order to make the crisis of one night its dramatic centre.

Kauśalyā: From Successor to Active Recogniser of Crisis

Kauśalyā does more than maintain an inherited ceremony. She notices changes in Burhba's voice. Rather than depend on rumour or an excited crowd, she goes directly to the peepal's roots, asks questions, and eventually organises a communal act of remembrance based on Godāvarī's proposal. Her agency has three levels: recognising a disturbance, listening to another person's counsel, and publicly enacting a new method. To reduce this to "she followed Godāvarī's advice" would underestimate her role in the practice of knowledge. Yet she does not directly know Burhba's inward suffering. Her initial understanding rests on the faint voice and his failure to appear. That limitation in focalization strengthens the plausibility of her response.

The First Scene of Silence: The Umpire Is Absent

Kabaddi begins on a new-moon night, but Burhba does not appear in his customary role as umpire. The children wait and ask one another, "Why hasn't Burhba come?" In this small piece of staging the older structure of the ritual suddenly becomes unstable. His absence is not merely a lack of sound; it threatens the continuity of a public rule. The children do not know why their judge is missing. Kauśalyā is frightened because the presence on which the night had always relied has abruptly become unavailable. An apparently negative event—someone's nonappearance—thus becomes an active turning point in the plot.

The Unusual Voice: Visibility through Hearing

After a long interval, Burhba's voice is heard very faintly, as though arriving "from far away, from great depth." The scene is constructed less through a physical body than through the intensity of sound, the delay before it is heard, and Kauśalyā's waiting. At first the narrator does not wholly reveal Burhba's inward exhaustion. Instead, weakness of sound generates mystery. "Silence" here is not the simple absence of speech but an experience of distance. Yet a faint voice does not independently establish the cause of the weakness. Burhba's later explanation gives the experience an interpretation; the two moments occupy different evidentiary positions.

"Hulāsā" or "Hulāsī": The Textually Demonstrated Uncertainty of Memory

Burhba says explicitly, "Hulāsā … or perhaps Hulāsī … Sukhdev, or Surendra …" This is not a mere uncertainty about pronunciation. It threatens the temporary failure of the function most central to his identity. Hulāsā and Hulāsī differ in vocal form, while Sukhdev and Surendra are distinct names altogether. If the dialogue is treated as direct evidence within the fictional

world, he experiences difficulty in retrieving the correct names at that moment. Later he says, "I was not forgetting," but that subsequent explanation does not erase the literal instability of the earlier speech. Two readings remain possible: a genuine temporary disturbance of memory or an impediment to retrieval arising from prolonged exhaustion. The text offers no decisive independent test between them.

Failure of Memory versus a Crisis of Access to Memory

Fear that information has permanently vanished differs from the inability to bring it into speech at a particular instant. Burhba says, "I am afraid I am beginning to forget." This is testimony about his subjective experience, not a conclusive diagnosis. He later attributes the experience to exhaustion, a new interpretation supplied by the character himself. Criticism should not announce that "there was no actual memory impairment" as an independently established fact. The material may have remained available but been temporarily inaccessible; alternatively, the name confusion may have represented partial deterioration. One night's emotional resolution does not completely settle the distinction.

The Witness's Fear: The Possibility of Failure inside Immortality

Burhba believes that he relinquished his human form to preserve names, yet now fears losing the ability to perform the task. The uncertainty of human old age is applied to an extraordinary witness who has survived for centuries. This is an important humanisation of his character. He who was regarded as changeless, unbroken, and unfailingly mindful must accept vulnerability. Earlier limitations concerned his vision of the forest in Chapter −84, the unknown primordial crocodile in −83, and the experiment of making his voice audible in −78. The present crisis is more intimate: it questions the reliability of his own memory rather than the scope of his vision of the outside world.

The Village's Fear: Dependence on a Single Institution of Memory

An elderly woman asks, "If Burhba forgets, with whom will our names remain?" The question reveals the community's anxiety. Although villagers have Burhba, kabaddi, and generations of oral transmission, the apparent withdrawal of one witness makes their future memory seem precarious. The narrative identifies the problem of a single point of institutional failure. The preceding chapter introduced Yādavānand's notebook, yet nobody invokes it during the present crisis. Either it was not reliably accessible to the community, or the author sets that narrative thread aside to serve a different purpose. The source does not decide between those possibilities.

Forming an Assembly: Several Centres of Communal Knowledge

The headman, elders, and a descendant of Sonmā the fisherwoman gather to deliberate. This assembly matters because public inquiry begins in place of Burhba's monopolistic answers. Initially the witness himself cannot supply a solution; the group must look for one. Yet the narrative does not develop the deliberations, competing proposals, or comparison of alternatives in detail. It quickly moves to Godāvarī's decisive question. A collective process is opened, but its dramatic emphasis falls on the insight of one speaker. The assembly is not fully realised as an institution; it functions chiefly as the setting for ethical discovery.

Godāvarī: Renewing Sonmā's Tradition

Godāvarī is descended from Sonmā the fisherwoman and belongs to a family associated with the distant waters of the Kamalā–Balān. Sonmā earlier taught Burhba patience and the complex relation of remembering to forgetting. Her successor asks a different question: why, while preserving the names of so many others, has Burhba's own name been neglected? The knowledge of the water-based tradition now becomes an ethics of collective care rather than a mysterious explanation of the crocodile. Lineage does not logically guarantee an identical perspective, but the novel deliberately creates a dialogue across generations. Without Godāvarī's intervention, the community might remain frightened merely by the weakening of a quasi-divine witness.

The One Named "Budhuā": Restoring the Human Being Who Preceded the Witness

Godāvarī asks whether Burhba's own name, "Budhuā," has ever been spoken publicly with respect. "Burhba" is a designation given by the community to describe his role; "Budhuā" belongs to his earlier, embodied life. In one identity the individual has almost become a function, while in the other there was a historical human being. Godāvarī asserts the person's right to remembrance alongside the remembrance of his work. The philosophical concerns with body and name from Chapter –100 acquire a new social form. Yet pronouncing "Budhuā" does not automatically produce a full life history. Godāvarī's question requires the community to hear his experiences, mourn his suffering, and sing his story.

"Vācaspati Miśra's Servant": A Double-Edged Labouring Identity

Kauśalyā introduces Budhuā as "Vācaspati Miśra's servant." This recalls his original position in the social order. Positively, the servant's own name becomes visible within the history of a major scholar. Yet it also risks defining his entire life through service to a famous man. Greater attention

to the worker's independent conditions—wages, rest, family relationships, private aspirations, and daily existence—might have given "Budhuā" a fuller humanity beyond a role label. The chapter restores the name but leaves the social meaning of labour open to further inquiry.

Care That Flows Only One Way: What Is the Problem?

Godāvarī asks who ever listened to Burhba's own story despite the thousands of names that were demanded from him. The point is not to diminish the importance of remembering the dead, but to expose an unequal distribution of care. The witness's responsibility appears endless, while the community's response to his needs has been absent. The narrative proposes that such one-sidedness produces inward depletion. But it supplies no complete firsthand history proving that nobody ever loved, honoured, or assisted him during the previous centuries. What is clearly established is that there had been no regular communal practice of remembering the witness himself. The analysis is stronger when grounded in this more limited claim.

Selfless Service and the Difference Made by Reciprocity

Kauśalyā praises Burhba's renunciation of humanity through love and says that he never requested anything for himself. This elevates the ideal of service. Godāvarī exposes the hidden problem: failing to ask for help does not prove that someone has no need of it. A just community cannot wait indefinitely for a caregiver, servant, or witness to complain; it should ask how much that person carries. Yet reciprocity should not be reduced to a calculation of payment for service. The novel argues for a restoration of human mutuality within generous acts, not for a fixed reward each time someone remembers a name.

Godāvarī's Solution: Changing the Structure of the Ritual

Godāvarī proposes that the village should do for Burhba what he has done for everyone else. This is more than a comforting speech. It publicly reverses the direction of the existing ritual. Instead of playing kabaddi in the witness's presence while invoking dead names, the witness himself becomes the object of remembrance. Kauśalyā asks what to do; Godāvarī offers an approach; and the village acts upon it together. The shared agency of these women temporarily shifts the narrative's knowledge-producing authority away from the extraordinary male figure. Burhba nevertheless gives the final explanation of what has happened, while an independent long-term test of the new practice remains absent.

The Social Limits of the Entire Village's Participation

The description says that "every person in the village" gathers near the peepal: old and young, children, the Brahmin quarter, and the leatherworkers' settlement. The scene imagines an evening of social equality. Earlier chapters depicted different caste-based geographies and unequal powers; here people come together for shared remembrance. But public attendance does not establish permanent equality of land, food, marriage, resources, or religious rights. Communal unity during a song and the village's lasting social structure are different levels of reality. The story persuasively depicts a possibility of collective grief and gratitude; it cannot be used as proof that entrenched caste, class, and gender inequalities have ended.

Budhuā's Extended Designation: A Sequence of Witnessed Lives

Kauśalyā first speaks the name "Budhuā," then adds "Vācaspati Miśra's servant," "witness to Hulāsā," "witness to Jīvantī," and witness to Sukhdev, Ratnā, Mālatī, Subhāgī, and Gaurī. This becomes the oral outline of an alternative biography: a sequence of roles, relationships, and remembered deeds. The names of many persons and generations make Budhuā a centre of interconnected lives. Yet his private desires, family relationships, and everyday existence outside acts of service remain scarce. The narrative honours his labour while continuing to define much of the person through that labour.

Repeating Each Fragment: From Individual Memory to a Social Collection

The assembly's participants take turns telling portions of Burhba's story: thirty years of service, the water burial, his helplessness during the first flood, the journey to Sonmā, and his anguish over Yaśpati. These events appeared separately in earlier chapters; their recurrence now reconstructs a public life rather than supplying an arbitrary summary. The contents of one witness's memory are distributed among many mouths. The community thereby begins to overcome dependence on a single keeper of names. But who tells which part, whether accounts conflict, and how disagreements are handled remain outside the narrated scene. Repetition demonstrates solidarity rather than flawless historical accuracy.

The Children's Free Dance: The Disappearance of Formal Kabaddi

The source states explicitly: "No formal kabaddi, only a spontaneous, joyful remembrance." That sentence must be taken seriously. Godāvarī frames her proposal through kabaddi; Kauśalyā lights lamps and invites public invocation; yet the children dance freely around the peepal rather

than follow the old rules. The actual event is an open transformation of ritual, not faithful observance of the traditional game. Accordingly, to say that a complete, formal turn of kabaddi was played in Burhba's honour would misdescribe the text. The spirit of the practice survives in naming and participation, while its operative rules are loosened. The alteration demonstrates vitality and also a limit to formal continuity.

The Children's Incomplete Understanding: What Must Remembrance Contain?

Children repeat parts of Burhba's story with reverence, even though they do not fully understand every part. The narrator treats this partial knowledge not as disqualification but as a natural stage of inclusion. Participation in public memory may begin through voice, rhythm, relationship, and feeling before complete historical comprehension is possible. Yet simply chanting "Burhba! Burhba!" cannot preserve all the facts of his life. Future generations still require sustained teaching, contextual narration, and examination of sources. The scene opens participation to children; it does not complete their historical education.

Light at the Peepal: Supernatural Event and Symbolic Meaning

After the communal remembrance, a slight but steady light rises from the peepal's roots, clearer and firmer than before. In the magical-realistic world the narrator describes this as a scene that occurs. Symbolically it represents the renewal of Burhba's inner strength. But the novel offers no scientific, biological, or physical explanation of the light's production. The universal statement "collective gratitude produces light" is not proven beyond the work of fiction. The image's artistic validity must be assessed according to its internal consistency and symbolic effects, not by pretending that the metaphor is a demonstrable physical mechanism.

The Voice Grows Strong Again: Direct and Indirect Limits of the Result

Burhba's voice becomes distinct once more; the narrator says it no longer trembles. The direct outcome established by the text is the immediate restoration of his voice. He thanks the community and says he has learnt the reciprocal nature of witnessing. Yet no separate test demonstrates that he now recalls every name correctly. The earlier confusions between Hulāsā/Hulāsī and Sukhdev/Surendra are not explicitly retested or corrected in a new scene. The narrative employs a stronger voice and ethical understanding as signs of renewed memory; criticism must distinguish these signs from direct verification.

"I Was Not Forgetting": The Logical Limits of Self-Interpretation

Burhba declares that Godāvarī was right and says, "I was not forgetting, Kauśalyā. I was only … tired." This is the character's retrospective interpretation of his experience. Several questions persist. If exhaustion caused the confusion, was the earlier failure to recall unreal or only temporary? If one evening's communal tribute relieved that exhaustion, is there evidence that it will not recur at the next new moon? The chapter does not supply that test. The literary resolution is emotionally meaningful, but it does not establish a clinical diagnosis of the memory disturbance or its permanent cure.

Modern "Compassion Fatigue": Figure of Thought versus Diagnosis

The appended commentary relates Burhba's condition to the modern concept of "compassion fatigue." As literary interpretation, the analogy is intelligible: listening to suffering for a long period, receiving little response to one's own experience, and becoming emotionally depleted. But Burhba's extraordinary existence, his centuries-spanning memory, and the light of a single night do not provide adequate grounds for a real medical diagnosis. "Compassion fatigue" should be used cautiously as a conceptual analogy, not as a demonstrated psychiatric condition or medically proven treatment.

"Flowing in Two Directions": A Social Transformation of the Water Metaphor

Burhba says that if witnessing moves only one way, the witness becomes empty; if it flows in two directions, it may continue without end. The novel's extensive imagery of water becomes a figure for social reciprocity. Rivers, ponds, floods, the crocodile's waters, and water burial previously carried danger and memory; here the act of flowing becomes the movement of support between people. The poetic achievement is concentrated. But reciprocal witnessing does not establish a physical or historical law of endless endurance. "Forever" expresses the ideal towards which the story aspires, whose institutional durability remains to be tested later.

Reciprocity and the Endless Network of Ethical Debt

Burhba's burden is not merely the number of names he holds. It is the absence of others who address him in turn. Godāvarī's answer teaches mutual recognition. Yet the critic must ask how the community should distribute the real work of memory beyond one annual ceremony. A living institution needs shared review of records, multiple means of listening, the possibility of hearing contrary accounts, and training of the young. The

chapter does not offer such a practical division of labour. The new rite of spoken gratitude initiates emotional balance, but does not fully reorganise the system of dependence upon a single witness.

The Full Moon of Phāgun: A New Rule of Time after the New Moon

At the end, the village institutes "Remembrance of Burhba" once each year on the full moon of Phāgun. The older preservation of names took place on new-moon nights; the new ceremony recounts Burhba's life under the light of the full moon. The contrast between new-moon darkness and full-moon brightness acquires symbolic force. The communal season of Phāgun, its songs, and its suggestions of renewal enrich the image. The text does not, however, describe an exact festival procedure, duration, meal, rules of play, or year-by-year development. Its declaration that the rite is held once a year establishes a narrated tradition without showing every future occurrence.

Frequency of Events: From One Night to an Annual Institution

One particular new-moon evening is presented in detail: silence, inquiry, gathering, song, light, and the returning voice. The narrator then summarises the introduction of the annual remembrance of Burhba. This is a move from singulative to iterative narration: one specific night becomes the model for recurring action in subsequent years. Yet no scene of the first actual full moon of Phāgun is supplied. The decision to add a custom is narrated; its successful practice throughout future centuries remains a summarized assertion. Such compression economises narrative space but reduces the realistic detail of institutional continuity.

Story Time and Narrating Time: Ten Years versus One Night

Nearly all the chapter's tension is concentrated on one new-moon night after a ten-year interval. Burhba's fatigue has apparently grown gradually, Kauśalyā has noticed its signs, and a decisive absence becomes visible during one performance. The contrast between an extended preceding condition and an immediate collective response makes the "moment when crisis becomes perceptible" the narrative centre. Yet the early stages of the fatigue have not been dramatized, and the community's response works with unusual speed. The story compresses duration for an emotional climax, leaving its causal demonstration incomplete from an epistemological perspective.

Focalization: From Kauśalyā's Anxiety to Burhba's Self-Explanation

Initially the narrator concentrates on Kauśalyā's concern and the children's waiting. The witness's inner condition reaches the reader through his weakened utterances. Godāvarī's question then alters

communal focalization: villagers begin examining their own conduct. Finally Burhba's strengthened voice provides the apparent explanation. The reader's knowledge therefore advances through three stages: visible disturbance, collective ethical interpretation, and personal testimony. The narrator does not disclose a definitive cause at the beginning; the final speech acquires almost conclusive authority, while opportunities for checking alternative explanations remain slight.

The Language of Silence: Pauses, Incomplete Names, and Responses

Burhba's speech repeatedly contains "I ...," alternative pronunciations of names, and indications of weak sound. Such punctuation makes silence visible within written language. The opening proverb says, "Silence is also an answer." But silence does not always mean meaningful agreement. Here it might indicate weakness, fear, shame, impaired retrieval, or the need to rest. Kauśalyā's questions and Godāvarī's interpretation allow an intelligible meaning to emerge. Silence is not independent and complete evidence; social listening selects among its possibilities. When the narrative rapidly decides that silence means "fatigue," the critic should keep the other possibilities available.

Navya-Nyāya Examination: Name Confusion as Reason, Fatigue as Conclusion

The disputed pakṣa concerns Burhba's weak voice and hesitant pronunciation of names. The proposed sādhya is exhaustion resulting from long, one-sided labour as a witness. The hetu offered is his burden of countless names and the lack of full reciprocal recognition. Yet the text does not demonstrate a universal concomitance between neglected caregivers and confusion of names. Nor does it exhaustively eliminate possible illness, changing rules of supernatural existence, temporary mental disturbance, or other causes. His voice improves after communal recognition, suggesting a possible remedial effect, but the causal certainty of a single occasion remains limited. The symbolic richness of literature is not diminished by distinguishing the author's moral lesson from an empirically demonstrated explanation.

Indian Poetics: A Sequence of Karuṇa, Adbhuta, and Śānta

At the beginning, compassion for Burhba's helplessness is the dominant response. His admission "I am afraid" deepens karuṇa, because the extraordinary witness himself is frightened. Godāvarī's question becomes an awakening of moral understanding; the illumination of the peepal provides a determinant of adbhuta; public invocation of his name and a new sense of balance suggest śānta. The phrase "spoken through silence" is central to the chapter's suggestive meaning: the cry of unrecognised labour

remained unheard. The problem of aucitya returns in the speed of relief. To resolve centuries of accumulated exhaustion in a single evening is dramatically effective but may also be considered a simplification.

Videha Parallel History: The Life of the Person Who Makes History

In this chapter the collector of history becomes a subject of historical narration. Budhuā was once a servant, then a witness to a water burial and to lives omitted from accepted records; the work of safeguarding others' names obscured his own former life. Godāvarī lifts that veil. Parallel history requires not only asking "Whose name was recorded?" but also "Whose record contains the work and life of the person who records names?" A female successor gives public form to the life of a male-coded supernatural witness. Yet the chapter does not show an analogous annual remembrance for the multigenerational caregiving work of Gaurī, Sonmā, Phulesarī, or their successors. Burhba's humanisation opens an important question; it does not settle justice for every invisible worker.

Table of Events, Evidence, and Causes

Event	Textually attested change of state	Evidentiary or narrative limit
Ten-year interval	Kauśalyā assumes responsibility for the ritual	Detailed process of succession absent
Burhba's voice gradually weakens	Kauśalyā recognises signs of a crisis	Underlying cause initially unknown
Umpire absent at the new moon	Children wait and the village begins to doubt	Absence itself is no diagnosis
Confusion over "Hulāsā/Hulāsī" and "Sukhdev/Surendra"	Character testimony shows a momentary lapse of memory	Permanent memory loss unproved
Godāvarī's question	Neglect of Budhuā's own name comes to the centre	No single cause established
Communal assembly	Reciprocal care becomes a public concern	No formal test of unanimity
Public remembrance of Budhuā's life	The witness's own history enters public memory	Not every biographical detail is provided
Children's spontaneous dance	The formal kabaddi ritual is transformed	Earlier rules not followed in full
Light around the peepal	Supernatural change in the scene	Physical cause unspecified
Burhba's stronger voice	Immediate restoration of audible speech	Later independent test of corrected names absent
"I was not forgetting"	Reinterpretation of his own experience	Earlier actual confusion of names not cancelled
Full-moon remembrance of Burhba in Phāgun	A new annual communal ritual is established	Its continued observance is not fully dramatised

Verbatim Source-Evidence Indicators from the Original Chapter

1. "When Burhba is silent, he speaks most of all" — opening proverb.

2. "Silence is also an answer" — initial ethical proposition.

3. "Ten years have passed" — the interval in the story.

4. "Burhba's voice" — the auditory form of his witnessing power.

5. "Why hasn't Burhba come?" — the children's uncertainty.

6. "Burhba, are you all right?" — Kauśalyā's direct inquiry.

7. "Tonight I cannot recall the names" — Burhba's admission of crisis.

8. "Hulāsā … or perhaps Hulāsī …" — uncertainty of pronunciation.

9. "Sukhdev, or Surendra …" — substitution of distinct names.

10. "I am afraid that I am forgetting" — the witness's fear.

11. "If Burhba forgets" — the village's shared anxiety.

12. "Burhba's own name—Budhuā" — Godāvarī's counter-question.

13. "Have you ever listened to his story?" — the witness's personal right.

14. "He always gave, and never received" — the one-way labour of memory.

15. "Then what shall we do?" — Kauśalyā's practical question.

16. "Tonight the turn shall be for Burhba's name" — Godāvarī's proposal.

17. "Budhuā! Servant of Vācaspati Miśra!" — restoration of personal history.

18. "Witness to Hulāsā! Witness to Jīvantī!" — biography through relationships.

19. "Who never asked for anything for himself" — ideal of selfless work.

20. "No formal kabaddi" — the actual limit of the old game structure.

21. "A spontaneous, joyful remembrance" — the new form of the rite.

22. "Godāvarī was right" — Burhba's acknowledgment of gratitude.

23. "I was not forgetting, Kauśalyā" — final self-interpretation.

24. "I was only … tired" — the cause asserted within the narrative.

25. "Being a witness is not a one-way task" — the principle of reciprocity.

26. "On the full moon of Phāgun" — annual time of the new custom.

27. “Those who understood Burhba's silence” — the concluding song's suggestion.

The brief translated quotations are taken from the original proverb, narration, dialogue, and song of Chapter –77. The printed range 209–212 refers to the chapter as a whole; individual page positions are not asserted without separate verification.

Overall Narratological Judgment

“Burhba's Silence” marks a decisive ethical change in the trilogy's architecture of memory. Burhba's exceptional power of “preserving names” had earlier served the excluded. Now the community acknowledges an obligation to remember the witness's own name. Kauśalyā's questions, Godāvarī's independent insight, the public calling of his name across social quarters, and the children's unregulated dance transform the story of a single witness into collective remembrance. This is the chapter's strongest creative achievement. Its weaknesses are equally specific: the unresolved evidentiary tension between demonstrated name confusion and its later explanation as mere fatigue; unusually rapid relief; the possibility of mistaking one night's social unity for enduring reform; and the incomplete rules for practical distribution of archival labour. The qualified literary judgment is positive. The work deepens the ethics of memory, but criticism must not endorse unsupported declarations about lasting social or psychological recovery.

Source Note and the Next Narrative Bridge

Primary source: Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, complete Maithili trilogy, Part 0, original Chapter –77, “Burhba's Silence,” combined manuscript, contents-based pages 209–212. The preceding manuscript entry reports 900 word units and 65.4 per cent action-indicative paragraphs, not an independently measured density of events. “The Exhaustion of Caregivers and the Need for Reciprocity” is post-chapter authorial commentary, not a medical diagnosis. Next: original Chapter –76, “The First Lesson on a Coconut Leaf,” concerning reading, writing, records made from leaves, and community education.

Critical Section 25 | Original Chapter −76 — The First Lesson on a Coconut Leaf

The Limits of the Original Text and the Analytical Commitment

Chapter −76 is the twenty-fifth independent chapter of the pre-narrative period. In the original novel it begins with a proverb and then presents Mandākinī, Kauśalyā's daughter, dissatisfied with the community's exclusion from learning; the caste restrictions of the established school; the cost of writing materials; an experiment making marks on a dried coconut leaf; a public lesson the following week; Burhba's response; and the subsequent establishment of a teaching tradition. This study treats the imagined beginnings of the "Coconut-Leaf School" as an event within the novel, not as a self-evidently established event in external educational history. The central question is how far a community can attain the autonomy to read and write its own history when the availability of materials and access to knowledge present two distinct obstacles.

From Chapter −77 to −76: From Dependence on a Witness to Independent Reading

In "Burhba's Silence," Kauśalyā and Godāvarī made Burhba's own life a subject of public remembrance. The community accepted an obligation to care for its witness. In this chapter Kauśalyā's daughter Mandākinī poses a harder question about the right to memory: what happens when one cannot read the account of one's own community, even when it has been written down? Previously the question was, "Who will hear the witness's own story?" Now it is, "Even if our story is recorded, how shall we learn its meaning for ourselves?" The movement is from emotional recognition of a person to the social ability to read and write. The ordinary alphabet lessons of children displace the supernatural witness's extraordinary powers of memory as the principal agents of narrative development. Thus the new interest in education follows causally from the earlier genealogical and manuscript episodes rather than appearing as an unrelated moral lesson.

The Original Dissatisfaction: Historical Authority "in Other People's Hands"

Mandākinī tells her mother that "our story is in other people's hands," but not "before our own eyes." The contrast reveals the profound distance between possession of records and independent access to what is written. Haripati recorded folk narratives; Yādavānanda copied names into a personal book. A community does not become able to read those records simply because they have been written. When the meaning of script

remains controlled by groups with earlier access to literacy, the people concerned cannot examine the evidence concerning their own lives. The apparent victory of preserving memory in writing therefore creates another form of dependence. "Before our eyes" signifies not just the sense of sight but the right to assess one's own history. Yet the chapter does not consider blind readers or alternative means of auditory access; making literacy exclusively visual is itself a limitation worth noting.

"Safeguarded in the Register": An Internal Discrepancy with the Earlier Story

In Mandākinī's understanding, or in the narrator's account of it, family histories are now preserved "on paper, and in the register." In Chapter –78, however, Yādavānanda expressly stated that his new notebook was not an official pañjī, and might never become one. If "register" here denotes an officially recognised genealogical record, the present assertion is in tension with the earlier episode. Perhaps ordinary speakers call the unofficial shadow register a pañjī, or perhaps the narrator has compressed the distinct forms of written record into a single expression. The text does not decide between these interpretations. Criticism must therefore not invent the fact that the leatherworkers' community has already won official recognition in the genealogical registers. The discrepancy matters precisely because the trilogy repeatedly examines the continuity of records over long periods of time.

The Brahmin Quarter's School: Two Gates, Caste and Gender

The village has a school teaching Sanskrit and Maithili, but according to the novel it admits only boys of higher castes and welcomes girls of no caste. These are two separate structures of exclusion: a caste barrier and the exclusion of all girls. Nor does the text establish that every boy of a socially privileged caste has equal access; the later participation of poorer Brahmin families exposes divisions of economic means. This is a significant social differentiation. The novel does not, however, dramatise the school's teachers, fees, actual lessons, penalties, or the prior experiences of excluded pupils. Exclusion is stated firmly by the narrator rather than unfolded through a sustained confrontation at the school gate.

"Where Will Our Children Learn?": Turning an Ethical Question into a Plan

Mandākinī's question is not merely a plaintive appeal; it opens a search for an institution. She immediately recognises a concrete obstacle: paper and palm leaves are expensive. Desire for education alone cannot provide writing materials, a location, instruction, or fellow learners. The narrative thus introduces economic circumstance in an effective way. Yet it gives no

contemporary prices or supply routes. "Expensive" expresses the characters' situation and is not a historical price schedule. The financial barrier and the separate prohibitions based on caste and gender should not be collapsed into one cause. The proposed school must answer both.

The Courtyard: From Dissatisfaction to Experiment

One day in her courtyard Mandākinī takes a dried coconut leaf and draws lines on it with a stick. Clear marks appear from what began as unplanned scratching. This is the conjunction of a concrete external event and a new experience of knowledge. No teacher or scholar has previously offered a solution: she tests a locally available substance herself. The narrator says that she started "without thinking," giving the discovery a quality of accidental, empirical insight. Nevertheless repeated trials—examining the dryness of the leaf, the point of the stick, the pressure required, the legibility and durability of letters—would have made the result more secure. The story moves swiftly from a successful mark to public instruction. Both its imaginative immediacy and its compression of experimentation must be acknowledged.

The Properties of the Local Material: Observation versus Physical Proof

The source describes the leaf as dry and sturdy, with clearly visible marks; it also contrasts a green inner layer with a dry outer surface. These are material observations within Mandākinī's fictional experiment. They are not verified modern botanical findings, nor do they establish that durable writing can be made without ink on every variety of coconut leaf. How long the impressed or incised marks survive and what happens when the leaf is folded remain untested in this episode. Its literary significance is the possibility of reducing the cost of instructional materials. A firm claim of technological effectiveness would require additional testing.

Dialogue with Her Mother: Kauśalyā's Experience and a New Generation's Idea

Mandākinī calls her mother and shows her the marks. Smiling, Kauśalyā observes that one thing Garh Nārikel has in abundance is coconut trees. She does more than celebrate the discovery: she relates an individual experiment to a community's natural resources. The questioning daughter, experienced mother, and knowledge of local ecology become complementary. Kauśalyā's pleasure also carries memories of the suffering borne by Vasundharā, Godāvarī, and earlier generations. Yet the narrative gives her no searching questions about failed trials, dangers, or practical teaching requirements. Immediate approval creates dramatic reassurance while shortening the struggle of establishing an institution.

"The Following Week": The Speed of Institutional Founding

Within a week Mandākinī and her friends collect and clean dried leaves and begin teaching children in an open space. An experimental mark has become a public classroom. The causal chain is important: marks can be made on a leaf; the possible cost is reconsidered; leaves are collected collectively; a shared place is chosen; children arrive. The intervening week, however, does not show teacher preparation, an alphabet system, a curriculum, attendance arrangements, or parental permission. The brief chapter compresses these practical links even though they are crucial to the credibility of democratised education.

The Teacher's Literacy: The Chapter's Major Internal Contradiction

At the beginning the source clearly states that no man or woman in the settlement—including Mandākinī herself—can read letters written by someone else. Yet one week later Mandākinī and her companions teach children to "draw letters." Making a mark and recognising, reading, and teaching the established Maithili alphabet are not the same skill. Who taught the teachers? Did a literate outsider assist them? Had Mandākinī already known the shapes of letters but not how to read connected writing? The text answers none of these questions. These are possible explanations, not facts established by the source. An indispensable intermediate step in the transmission of literacy is missing; that gap must be identified without inventing a teacher.

"Drawing Letters" and Becoming Literate: Stages of Learning

The original expression "drawing letters" requires particular attention. Tracing a shape, recognising its sound, combining letters, reading a word, writing a name, and verifying a historical account constitute distinct stages. The first class is shown learning to trace letters, not immediately mastering an existing manuscript. The narrator's later summary of the school's long life suggests the possibility of further development, but does not dramatise its instructional method. Distinguishing the first stage from the full achievement of literacy strengthens rather than diminishes the value of the innovation.

The Place Where Drums Were Dried: Labour Reorganised as Education

The new classroom occupies an open area previously used to dry drums and mṛdaṅgas in the leatherworkers' settlement. The choice does not reject the earlier culture of labour: it creatively reuses a shared working space. Drums, mṛdaṅgas, and coconut leaves form the material surroundings of instruction. But did classes interfere with the drying of instruments? Who

agreed to change the use of the space? The chapter does not explore those questions. It presents a successful imaginative appropriation of shared space while leaving changes to everyday work undetermined.

Boys and Girls Together: An Answer to Gender Exclusion

Both boys and girls attend the new school. This directly opposes the established school's exclusion of girls. A woman initiates the alternative, and her agency has visible social importance. Nevertheless opening the door is not the same as guaranteeing a lasting right to education. How long girls study, how family labour or marriage affects their attendance, and how women's leadership of the institution is transmitted are not shown. The chapter establishes a practical beginning and a principle of inclusion, not a complete demonstration of educational equality.

Poor Brahmin Families: Distinguishing Class from Caste

Some poor Brahmin families also send their children to the open school because they cannot afford the costly alternative. The detail exposes economic inequalities within a socially privileged caste. The possibility of caste prestige is one thing; the ability to pay for schooling is another. Children from beyond the leatherworkers' quarter participate, crossing a real boundary in social practice. Yet "some families" does not mean all Brahmin households, nor does it document the attendance of nomadic, landless, disabled, or every other marginalised group. The episode moves toward inclusion without demonstrating universal access.

Were Girls from Poor Brahmin Families Included? An Evidentiary Qualification

The narrative states both that boys and girls were admitted and that some poor Brahmin families sent their children. Read together, these statements suggest a school challenging caste and gender exclusion. But the text does not identify how many of those families sent girls or whether every child attended regularly. Its inclusive norm is explicit; the finer distribution of actual attendance is not. A school being "open to all" and every previously excluded group benefiting from it are different conditions. That distinction should not be erased in the name of the author's evident egalitarian intention.

Reconfiguring Resources: The Limits of "Necessity Is the Mother of Invention"

The explanatory note following the original chapter associates affordable education with accessible local materials. The leaf experiment provides a compelling literary instance of creative action under scarcity. But poverty does not universally produce innovation. Materials, assistance, labour,

time, and collective decisions all contribute. In the terms of Navya-Nyāya, scarcity may be one condition among cooperative causes, not a sufficient hetu. Mandākinī's question, the properties of the leaf, Kauśalyā's support, her friends' work, and the available common space jointly make the school possible. The achievement becomes more intelligible when its plurality of causes is recognised.

The Coconut Tree: Geography, Ecology, and Schooling

Kauśalyā asks, in effect, what Garh Nārikel does not lack: coconut trees. Their leaves become a potentially low-cost educational resource. Tree, leaf, dried surface, and traced letter form a chain linking environment with the distribution of knowledge. Yet the extraction rate, sustainability of leaf collection, possibilities of reuse, and fate of discarded leaves remain unspecified. The proverb's claim that the tree "keeps history" is poetic; it does not prove that a mark scratched on an individual leaf will survive for centuries.

Burhba's Declaration: The Ideational Centre of the Chapter

Burhba calls Mandākinī's work the next step in the whole story. He recalls Hulāsā's inability to make a written copy, Ratnā's herbal knowledge going unrecorded, and the dependence of Gaurī, Sāvitrī, and Vasundharā's histories upon other people. These named memories expose a recurring deprivation: the women have experiences worth witnessing, but lack independent access as writers and readers. Burhba's approval places the school in the trilogy's larger history. Yet Mandākinī's own initiative is the primary cause. The prestige of the male supernatural witness must not eclipse the independent work of a woman founder. In this episode, the old witness can himself learn the meaning of literacy from a younger generation, even though he voices the formal blessing.

Ratnā's Healing Knowledge: The Possibility of a Written Tradition

Burhba recalls that Ratnā could not record her knowledge of herbs. Literacy therefore has implications beyond lists of names: botanical observations, methods of care, practical skills, and women's knowledge might become available for comparison and preservation. But the chapter does not test the efficacy, standardisation, or conditions of use of Ratnā's treatments. Recording remedies is not equivalent to validating their medical effects. Respect for transmitted knowledge and rigorous examination are compatible; literacy could make comparison of variants and critical testing easier. This is a future possibility, not an already demonstrated scientific accomplishment.

Written Stories and Living Witnesses: Mandākinī's Penetrating Challenge

Mandākinī asks Burhba whether people who can write their own stories will have less need of the kabaddi ritual of remembrance. This is the chapter's genuine intellectual debate. The young founder questions the continued necessity of an established institution rather than simply requesting its guardian's blessing. Her challenge has a logical form: if a written record sufficiently achieves the preservation of memory, what additional function is served by collective oral performance? Burhba replies that writing and bearing witness are different tasks. The distinction is significant, though a more detailed comparison of when written records are more reliable and when oral memory can be corrected would have sharpened the exchange.

Burning, Tearing, and Not Reading: The Vulnerability of Written Matter

Burhba points out that a written text can be burned, torn, or left unread. These are different vulnerabilities: physical destruction, deliberate suppression, and social indifference. His answer qualifies the earlier, idealistic faith in the centuries-long protection offered by Haripati's manuscript. Oral memory, however, is also vulnerable to forgetting, death, altered testimony, and collective pressure; Burhba's confusion over Hulāsā/Hulāsī in Chapter –77 directly demonstrated the point. It would therefore be wrong to conclude simply that writing perishes while speech is secure. Each medium has distinctive failures, making mutual scrutiny necessary.

"Each Protects the Other": A Dual-Medium Theory of Memory

Burhba's most mature proposition is that written stories and living memory are not rivals or substitutes: they protect one another. An oral tradition may reconstruct part of a destroyed record; a written account may provide a basis for comparing distorted spoken variants. This reciprocity is plausible, but it remains a proposed method rather than a completed demonstration. There is no scene in which a song is checked against a coconut-leaf text, a disputed name collectively corrected, or a written source used to resolve an oral disagreement. If Chapter –77 had allowed the confusion of names to be checked against written evidence, the two-media principle would have acquired immediate practical force. Here it remains an intellectually strong, incompletely instituted ideal.

The Philosophical Difference between Writing and Testimony

Writing is the production of signs. Bearing witness entails experience, trustworthiness, social responsibility, and openness to opposing questions. In this respect Burhba's distinction is sound. Someone may write an unsupported assertion on paper; its written form does not make it true evidence. Oral tradition is not inherently infallible either. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, pramāṇa depends upon the proposition, the speaker's reliability, context, meaning, and possible defeating considerations, not merely the endurance of a medium. Children learning to write names will eventually need to ask who supplied each name, when an event occurred, and whether conflicting testimony exists. The narrative establishes the first stages of schooling, not a complete curriculum in evidence criticism.

Haripati's Manuscript and Mandākinī's Leaf: The Right of Authorship

In Chapter –80 Haripati gathered community stories for three months and wrote them on palm leaves, while Indumatī protested, "This story belongs to us." Mandākinī now seeks a material answer to the dependence this exposed. People who had relied upon the visiting writer's pen begin to produce their own letters. But tracing the alphabet does not automatically settle literary ownership. Which language will they write in, for which readers, under what editorial practices, and with what rights retained by the source community? These questions survive the first lesson. The experiment is a powerful beginning against monopoly, not a completed history of independent community authorship.

The Institutional Link between Yādavānanda's Notebook and the School

In Chapter –78 Yādavānanda copied Vasundharā's three-hour genealogical testimony but intended to keep his book himself. Mandākinī's dissatisfaction gives concrete social meaning to this dependence. Yet the present chapter never shows a copy being brought to the settlement, read there, or corrected by its inhabitants. A new means of literacy does not instantly grant access to older restricted records. It equips a community with the potential to examine them later. Without that distinction, "we can now read" would be improperly transformed into "all errors in our historical register have already been corrected."

Education and Evidentiary Autonomy: The Navya-Nyāya Implication

Mandākinī's words "not before our own eyes" concern independent access to written signs. They should not be simply equated with philosophical pratyakṣa. Reading uses sight but also conventional language, memory, and the understanding of meaning. Tracing "ka" and "kha" on a leaf

begins the recognition of symbols; deciding whether a written story is true requires inquiry into its sources, coherence, and context. The freedom sought is therefore more than letter recognition. It includes the right to question witnesses, other accounts, and the reliability of sources. The new school potentially extends the novel's earliest philosophical debates into the social distribution of knowledge.

The Narrative Significance of the "First Letter": An Epoch in a Small Gesture

No war is won, no kingdom changes, and no crocodile manifests in this chapter. A child's first letter on a small leaf becomes the centre of a possible public transformation. The initial shell-and-silver debate concerned mistaken knowledge of an object; now the question is who is entitled to possess and test knowledge at all. The point of a stick held by a child is an ordinary object freighted with historical possibility. The disproportion between a minor bodily action and its social implications works beautifully. Yet the shape of the first letter, the identity of the first pupil, and the difficulty of learning it are not shown. The founding episode remains more a collective declaration than a finely observed lesson.

Continuity: Mandākinī Teaches into Old Age

The narrator states that until old age Mandākinī distributed leaves each morning and taught new children their first letters. A week's collective experiment becomes the repeated labour of a teacher's lifetime. This duration gives the "Coconut-Leaf School" meaning beyond its symbolic founding. But Mandākinī's livelihood, health, holidays, payment, home responsibilities, and the preparation of successor teachers are absent. Chapter –77 raised the problem of Burhba's centuries of one-sided service and exhaustion. Here another person works without stated compensation for decades, yet the narrative does not ask the same questions about her burden. The two chapters create a telling ethical intertext.

Becoming a Permanent Institution: Recognised by Whom?

According to the narrator, an informal gathering eventually became a "recognised tradition." This could signify communal acknowledgment or official sanction, but the source does not say which. It cannot establish state accreditation, a legal curriculum, or the appointment of professional teachers. Recurrent village acceptance could itself provide cultural legitimacy. Institutional examination would still ask about schedules, succession, money, admission, teaching standards, and learning outcomes. The text gives a summary of survival, not an administrative history of the school.

"Every Generation": The Limits of an Inclusive Generalisation

The narrator broadly says that children in each generation continued learning letters without distinctions of caste and gender. The founding class is described directly; later classes are not separately staged. This is a movement from a singulative beginning to iterative narration over many years. Narrative compression allows a large historical design, but cannot independently verify that every child in every generation received uninterrupted education. Poverty, illness, flooding, or renewed social opposition may have affected attendance; the text does not investigate. "Every generation" is an idealising, future-oriented narrative summary rather than an audited record of equal access.

Narrative Time: One Day, One Week, and Old Age

The temporal organisation has three clear stages: one day of experiment, one week until the public lesson, and many subsequent years of teaching. The first two offer recognisable scenes; the third is highly compressed summary. Readers can perceive a line from discovery to enduring institution without being shown intervening conflicts. This serves the scale of the larger trilogy: a yearly history of every local institution would overwhelm it. Yet the price is a reduced representation of daily work, resistance, revision, and failure. The result is an effective narrative formula but an incomplete social history.

Focalisation: Mandākinī's Experience and the Narrator's Authority

Initially the narrative approaches Mandākinī's "strange dissatisfaction" and her conversation with her mother. The marks emerging upon the leaf are almost experienced through her eyes, and her cry of delight focuses the discovery. Later the narrator assumes broad historical authority, announcing old age, permanence, and the instruction of "every generation." The summary thus acquires greater certainty than the young woman's observable experience. Burhba calls the discovery the next step in the whole story, providing moral authorization. Criticism must not reduce Mandākinī to an executor of a male witness's intentions: the initiative and experiment are hers.

Characterisation: A Thinking Young Woman or an Idealised Founder?

Mandākinī asks questions, experiments independently, gathers companions, begins teaching, and challenges the continued necessity of kabaddi. These actions give her genuine agency without requiring supernatural powers. But the narrative develops little of her hesitation, unsuccessful attempts, personal life, her friends' independent identities, or the source of her own knowledge of letters. She is convincing as the

founder of an idea; she could have been more fully developed as a complex person. The symbolic success does not cancel this limitation.

The Anonymous Collective Labour of Her Friends

The original clearly says that Mandākinī's friends help collect and clean leaves and conduct the class. The achievement therefore depends on collective gathering, cleaning, and teaching, not on the founder's insight alone. Yet their names, prior skills, social differences, and methods remain unspecified. A saga pledged to preserving every name leaves the women who actually build a school nameless. "Mandākinī founded the school" is a cultural truth within the narrative, but it does not fully account for the female labour that made the institution possible. Parallel history should identify the work supported by the source without fabricating names for its workers.

The Economics of Education: Free Leaves and a Teacher's Labour

A locally available leaf can be inexpensive; education is not thereby cost-free. Collecting and preparing leaves, running classes, bringing children, providing time away from other labour, and sustaining a teacher all require resources. The chapter gives no economic accounting of those activities. Mandākinī continues working every morning into old age, with no description of compensation or care. A positive story of overcoming shortage thus risks normalising unpaid work by women. The objection seeks to understand the actual relations of production behind an achievement, not to deny the achievement itself.

The Folk Song: The Sound of Learning and Collective Rhythm

The concluding song invokes the alphabet—"a to ā, ka to kha"—so that learning becomes communal recitation. The old collective call of kabaddi is transformed into the rhythm of letters. The inherited culture survives by acquiring a different educational purpose. The line "Whoever learns a letter today will preserve a name tomorrow" expresses an aspiration. Between letter recognition and responsible preservation of the causes, evidence, and accountability of injustice lie many further stages. The song conveys the joy of beginning to learn and the community's vow, not a measured educational result.

"Twelve Hundred Years": The Life of a Leaf or a Symbolic Period?

The song also says that what was written on the coconut leaf was read for "twelve hundred years." This connects the long pre-narrative timespan, Burhba's extraordinary memory, and the tradition imagined to reach later readers. Yet the original does not establish that marks made on one particular dried leaf physically endured for twelve centuries. Repeated

writing by successive generations could preserve a practice without preserving the same object. Literary criticism should read the number as poetic hyperbole or a traditional temporal bridge unless material evidence is given.

Indian Poetics: Wonder, Utsāha, and the Movement toward Śānta

The first successful marks inspire astonishment and delight. Kauśalyā's smile carries an aftertone of the suffering of older generations; the community's class creates collective enthusiasm, a nonviolent social form of vīra. Alphabet recitation and the theory of mutually supporting written and oral memory suggest a balanced śānta-like disposition. It would be artificial to claim that the chapter displays every classical rasa. In the suggestive register, the leaf becomes a local resource, the letter becomes a claim to knowledge, and the tree evokes enduring communal history. A serious question of aucitya remains: how did a founder initially unable to read become a teacher of the alphabet only a week later? The missing causal link reduces the credibility of the transformation.

Videha Parallel History: Authorship by the Community That Supplies the Sources

The marginalised settlement begins to change from a subject of history into a possible community of readers and writers. Haripati and Yādavānanda were outsiders recording its histories; Mandākinī finds a means of learning inside the community's own material environment. This alters the possibility of self-representation, not merely the number of readers. Nevertheless practical tests remain: admission, trained teachers, ownership of narratives, accuracy of names, editorial methods, and public access to written records. Parallel history is not the practice of declaring every marginalised utterance unquestionable; it extends the range of sources while preserving fair evidentiary examination.

Navya-Nyāya: A Chain of Contributory Causes from Discovery to Literacy

The pakṣa is the children of the leatherworkers' settlement previously denied education; the proposed sādhya is the beginning of accessible instruction. The hetu is not just the capacity of a dry leaf to retain a mark, but the abundance of leaves, the labour of Mandākinī and her friends, and an available meeting place. None is sufficient by itself. There is no established universal vyāpti from "free leaves" to "complete literacy." Teachers without materials are hindered; materials without a teacher and a system of letters are useless; an open classroom without social access is incomplete. What the novel actually narrates is the founding of leaf-based letter practice followed by a summary asserting continuity. Carefully

specifying the causal conditions makes its innovation more credible and its conclusions more proportionate.

A Bridge to Chapter −75: Education Produces Questions

The next chapter, "Reason's First Rebellion," begins with an educated generation questioning established customs. That possibility is a potentially unforeseen result of Chapter −76. Literacy does not merely improve the faithful recording of ancestral memory: it also grants the right to criticise written claims. Mandākinī has already asked Burhba whether the kabaddi ritual remains necessary. A following generation will ask what evidence supports the witness's existence. That development belongs to the next chapter and must not be reported as already occurring in this one. The freedom created by education may include disagreement with its founders' own traditions; this productive contradiction enriches the narrative.

Table of Events, Evidence, and Ethical Implications

Event or decision	Direct material from the original text	Evidentiary limit	Critical significance
Mandākinī's initial dissatisfaction	Neither the people of the quarter nor she herself can read written letters	Specific level of literacy unknown	Demand for independent use of written history
Exclusion from the Brahmin-quarter school	Only high-caste boys admitted; girls excluded	No formal rulebook presented	Distinct caste and gender exclusions
Cost of paper and palm leaves	Obstacle to procuring materials for children	No historical price table	Economic barrier to education
Drawing with a stick on dried coconut leaf	Legible marks become visible	Permanence of writing untested	Experimental potential of local material
Kauśalyā's endorsement	Remembrance of plentiful coconut trees in the village	Long-term supply volume unknown	Maternal support and environmental knowledge
Collective leaf gathering next week	Labour of Mandākinī and unnamed friends	Time and value of labour not recorded	From experiment to public organisation
First class	Girls and boys together learn to trace letters	How the teacher herself learned remains unanswered	Major gap in transmission of knowledge
Arrival of some poor Brahmin children	Economic reasons lead them to the new school	Actual caste and gender proportions unknown	Difference between class and caste
Burhba's spoken endorsement	Connects ancestors' unwritten stories with new literacy	Children do not become fully literate immediately	Social purpose of memory
Mandākinī's question about kabaddi	Challenges the need for writing and memorisation	Two-medium method not experimentally tested	Beginning of a new debate
Burhba's answer about writing and orality	Recognises risk of leaf and paper deteriorating	Oral memory has errors too	Possibility of mutual verification

Event or decision	Direct material from the original text	Evidentiary limit	Critical significance
Future of the permanent school	Tradition is recognised; Mandākinī teaches into old age	Who confers institutional recognition is unspecified	Social value of repeated labour
Closing alphabet song	Communal articulation from a to ā, ka to kha	A coconut leaf's lifespan of twelve hundred years unproved	Literary time-effect and enthusiasm for education

Register of Verbatim Source-Evidence Indicators

1. "The first lesson on a leaf—how a name is written" — opening proverb.

2. "The leaf that keeps a name, the tree that keeps history" — arboreal metaphor.

3. "Our story is in other people's hands" — Mandākinī's experience of dependence.

4. "But not before our own eyes" — the right of reading.

5. "Where will our children learn?" — the demand for public education.

6. "Paper and palm leaves were expensive" — material barrier.

7. "A dried coconut leaf" — substance used in the experiment.

8. "The line emerged clearly" — initial observable outcome.

9. "Look! I can write on a coconut leaf!" — Mandākinī's announcement.

10. "What is there no shortage of in Garh Nārikel?" — Kauśalyā's ecological reasoning.

11. "The following week" — transition to the collective class.

12. "Both boys and girls" — stated inclusion by gender.

13. "Some poor families" — indicator of economic difference.

14. "What you have done is the next step in our whole story" — Burhba's evaluation.

15. "They will write their own stories" — anticipated autonomy.

16. "Will its necessity diminish?" — Mandākinī's question about the ritual.

17. "Writing and bearing witness are two different tasks" — Burhba's distinction.

18. "Someone can burn what is written" — impermanence of records.

19. "You need both" — the proposal for two media.

20. “Not substitutes for one another, but each other’s guardians” — complementary memory.

21. “Until old age” — duration of teaching.

22. “A to ā, ka to kha” — the alphabet song.

23. “Whoever learns a letter today will preserve a name tomorrow” — future aspiration.

24. “What was written on a coconut leaf was read for twelve hundred years” — poetic magnification of time.

These brief extracts are drawn from the proverbs, narration, dialogue, and closing song of original Chapter –76. No unverified pinpoint page references have been supplied.

Comparative Judgment: Achievement and Contradiction

The chapter achieves four things. First, a marginalised community begins moving from being the object of history toward reading and potentially writing history for itself. Second, locally available environmental resources turn an abstract right to education into a concrete class. Third, Mandākinī remains an active questioner, challenging the relation of collective remembrance and writing even after Burhba praises her discovery. Fourth, oral memory and writing are made complementary, not enemies. The narrative nevertheless retains a serious gap: Mandākinī, described as unable to read, becomes an alphabet teacher without any intervening account of how she learned. The school’s swift establishment, the anonymity of its collaborators, the unclear source of later recognition, and untested hopes for the durability of materials are further limitations. Identifying these gaps is not a rejection of educational democratisation; it is a demand for more credible narration of how it occurs.

Overall Narratological Conclusion and the Next Link

The significance of “The First Lesson on a Coconut Leaf” lies not in a supernatural miracle but in the material beginnings of communal education. A stick’s mark on a leaf suggests the first possibility of independent record-making after centuries of reliance upon others’ pens. Burhba’s memory, Haripati’s manuscript, Yādavānanda’s shadow register, and Kauśalyā’s care for the witness acquire a new practical direction. The first class is narrated as an event; perpetual educational equality is asserted in the narrator’s later summary. Keeping that distinction intact allows the chapter to bring together educational justice, female agency, labour, environment, and epistemology without mistaking idealistic claims for documented outcomes. Its missing pedagogical link and the future of its material resources remain questions. The following chapter’s educated

generation will begin to disagree with inherited tradition. The most mature implication is therefore that education gives people not just the power to write names but the right to ask questions.

Sources and Paratextual Qualification

Primary source: Gajendra Thakur, Gohi Sabhak Beech Jalsamadhi, complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter –76, "Nārikel Pātak Pahil Pāṭh," printed pages 213–216 according to the original contents. The earlier original-Maithili-manuscript analytical entry records 727 word units and 54.2 per cent action-indicating paragraphs; that percentage is not independently equivalent to event density. The post-chapter comment on innovating with scarce materials and democratising education is an explanatory paratext. It identifies the founding of the coconut-leaf school as fictional. The novel's event and external educational history must not be conflated. The next section concerns Chapter –75, "Reason's First Rebellion."

Critical Section 26 | Original Chapter −75 — Reason's First Rebellion

Textual Basis, Method of Examination, and the Central Question

Chapter −75 is the twenty-sixth independent chapter of the pre-narrative period. Its original sequence includes the outcomes of three generations of the community school, Viśvanāth's education in town, his public refusal to join the new-moon game, debate with his grandmother, other youths' withdrawal, new losses of livestock, the observation of unfamiliar marks in the forest, a conversation with Burhba, and a conditional return to participation. This review keeps observed action, the characters' inferences, the supernatural witness's speech, narratorial summaries, and the author's post-chapter commentary in distinct evidentiary categories. The central question is not which of faith and reason "wins." It is whether the novel genuinely allows a dissenter to test tradition or whether the apparent test ultimately serves to confirm what the tradition already maintains.

The Unforeseen Consequence of Chapter −76's Educational Achievement

In "The First Lesson on a Coconut Leaf," Mandākinī demanded the right to read and initiated instruction in letters so that the people's history would not remain in other people's hands. Chapter −75 presents a further result of this education: literate young people question the inherited ceremony of remembrance. This is effective narrative development. Education is not merely a technique for following ancestors' commands more efficiently; it creates the possibility of critical freedom. Mandākinī's initiative thus bears fruit even in disagreement with her own family's tradition. The unexpected result gives the younger generation agency and reveals that institutions cannot fully control what their learners will do. Yet Viśvanāth eventually returns to kabaddi. The critical question becomes whether the independence of the newly educated mind survives, or whether a frightening episode returns it to established reverence.

Three Generations of Story Time: Repetition and Compressed History

The opening states that "Mandākinī's school flourished for three generations." This single sentence absorbs many years of classes, teachers, pupils, and domestic change. Viśvanāth is identified as Mandākinī's great-grandson, establishing a genealogical interval without supplying exact ages, foundation dates, or dates for the town school. Once again the narrator compresses extended time, expands one new-moon debate into a

scene, moves several months forward, and then returns to the immediate drama of the forest. In Genette's terms, it is a movement through summary, scene, intervening ellipsis, and renewed scene. This technique preserves the trilogy's broad timescale, but leaves the distinctive experiences of three generations of learners almost entirely in summary.

The Social Composition of a Newly Literate Community

The chapter says that children from leatherworker, Brahmin, and Kāyastha households are reading letters, performing calculations, and discovering the pleasures of books. The narrator thereby claims a widening of the school's effects. Yet the broad expression "all" is not supported by a separate register of every family, girl, or occupational community. What matters is that people formerly denied education can now enter into dialogue with formal instruction in logic outside the village. The reference to arithmetic indicates practical reasoning rather than merely the repetition of sacred texts. The actual curriculum, learning outcomes, and institutional rules of questioning, however, remain unspecified. The courage to argue should not be attributed mechanically to books alone, without considering teachers, families, discussion, and the social environment.

The Name Viśvanāth: Explicitly Distinguishing Two Namesakes

A parenthetical note states that this Viśvanāth is "different from Yaśpati's victim, though he happens to bear the same name." The clarification is indispensable in a narrative spanning many generations. The present Viśvanāth is Mandākinī's great-grandson, not the boy who suffered during the earlier witchcraft conspiracy. The text does not give the shared name a further verified causal connection with the other life. Within this long novel, names preserve memory but can also create confusion of identity. The old philosophical concern with mistaken identification returns here in genealogical form. Sharing a name cannot serve as an invariable reason for identifying two people as one; the source explicitly prevents that error.

Two Years of Study in Town: The Entrance of Outside Knowledge

Viśvanāth has spent two years in a newly established town school, where he has encountered logic, mathematics, and new ideas before returning to the village. The narrative function of this journey is to bring external academic discipline into a local regime of memory. Mandākinī's school supplied a foundation in reading; the town school gives doubt a wider vocabulary. But which philosophical school, mathematical exercises, and texts shaped him are not specified. He should not therefore be portrayed as a documented representative of a particular Western scientific movement. He is a rationally inclined character who questions causal claims about the

inherited rite, not someone shown to possess an experimentally verified account of every natural or supernatural possibility.

The New-Moon Stage: Non-participation Is Itself an Action

When the rite begins, Viśvanāth does not join the game. He stands at the edge with folded arms. This posture gives dissent a visible form. Previously the community of the new moon consisted of performers and sympathetic spectators; now a spectator claims the right to critical distance. He does not stop the game, destroy the field, or attack the participants. He withdraws his own participation. That distinction is ethically important: freedom to question a practice is different from imposing a prohibition upon others. His body marks a division between the cultural centre around the peepal and the questioning position at the edge. How the community tolerates this distance becomes the test of the ensuing dialogue.

The First Exchange with His Grandmother: Authority and Fear

Viśvanāth approaches his grandmother, warning that what he is about to say may hurt her. This is not a crude rejection but doubt expressed with awareness of a relationship's vulnerability. She is stunned because she is the present guardian of the ceremony; a domestic disagreement threatens the authority of a public custom. The grandmother appeals to testimony transmitted across generations: her great-grandmother had seen, and her mother had heard. But the objects, occasions, and temporal distance of seeing and hearing are not identical. Their combined testimony is not thereby independent present-day observation. The grandmother does not simply punish the question; she offers the family's available grounds of belief. That restraint is one of the novel's strengths.

Viśvanāth's Proposition: A Beautiful Game, an Uncertain Cause

Viśvanāth calls the rite "a beautiful tradition" while asking whether the crocodile or Burhba might be creations of ancestral imagination. He separates aesthetic and communal value from a claim about supernatural causation. A game may preserve collective memory and companionship even if its power to prevent natural disaster remains unproved. His use of "perhaps" matters: he does not offer a final disproof, but a possible alternative explanation for the stories. Calling him an unquestioning atheist, the final voice of science, or a traitor to his ancestors would therefore exceed the original. His intellectual position combines provisional doubt with respect for what the rite means to others.

"Human Memory Can Be Deceptive": Legitimate Objection and Overgeneralisation

Viśvanāth suggests that memories can mislead and folktales may grow as they pass from generation to generation. The possibility is supported by Burhba's literal confusion in Chapter –77 between Hulāsā and Hulāsī, and between Sukhdev and Surendra. But "memories sometimes err" does not establish that every inherited account is certainly false. Nor does Viśvanāth actually make that comprehensive claim. He demands evidentiary caution. In philosophical terms the possibility of error justifies testing pratyakṣa and śabda, not discarding all witnesses in advance. A fuller answer would examine names, dates, independent accounts, and alternative causes. The novel allows a legitimate question to enter communal life without yet completing its evidentiary resolution.

"With My Own Eyes, with My Own Reason": Self-Government in Evidence

Viśvanāth wants to view the world with his own eyes and judgment. His words echo Mandākinī's earlier complaint that "our stories" were not "before our own eyes." Mandākinī sought independent access to written language; Viśvanāth seeks independence in evaluating the claims contained in that language and in oral traditions. The progression marks the social maturity of education. Nevertheless exclusive reliance upon sight also requires criticism, since visual perception itself can mislead; the opening shell-and-silver problem had established precisely this in the trilogy. Reason must work with perception, language, memory, inference, and possible defeating evidence. Viśvanāth expresses a beginning of independent epistemology, not its completed system.

The Spread of Dissent: From a Private View to Public Conduct

His words circulate in the village and some other youths stop playing kabaddi. An individual opinion now changes collective participation. Yet these youths remain unidentified: the text gives neither their number, the duration of their withdrawal, nor their independently articulated reasons. Consequently it is incorrect to announce that the entire custom ceased. The narrator's subsequent summary says that the game became irregular, not that every new moon was cancelled. The causal movement from one person's challenge to reduced attendance is narratively clear, while the roles of persuasion, prestige, family pressure, and possible sanctions remain uncertain.

Changing Numbers of Young Players: Attendance Is Not Proof of a Doctrine

The narrator says that for the first time in hundreds of years the gathering at the peepal began to diminish. This indicates a public crisis of inherited confidence, not the non-existence of the supernatural being. Equally, the previous large crowds never provided universal proof that the crocodile existed. Attendance measures social practice, not the truth of a metaphysical proposition. The numerical decrease is an expansive narratorial description rather than a documented statistical series. Viśvanāth becomes more than an isolated dissenter, but refusing a supernatural explanation and withdrawing from social companionship are not necessarily identical actions.

Burhba's Initial Response: Not Treating a Question as an Enemy

Villagers expect Burhba to be angry or hurt. Instead he says, "Let him come," welcoming inquiry. An extraordinary witness does not prohibit criticism of his own existence or role. This is ethically one of the chapter's strongest moments. Yet Burhba adds that he knows something Viśvanāth does not yet know. The remark establishes an asymmetry of knowledge and foreshadows a later revelation. Why has that allegedly superior knowledge not been made available to open testing? Burhba's patience is commendable, but the posture of a master guarding undisclosed insight is not intellectual equality. The following forest episode gives this assertion narrative force without fully explaining what he knows.

Vācaspati, Udayana, and Gaṅgeśa: The Legitimacy of Asking Questions

Burhba links Viśvanāth's scepticism to the questioning intellectual traditions associated with Vācaspati Miśra, Udayanācārya, and Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. This list connects the chapter with the trilogy's philosophical dramas and wider design around Nyāya and Navya-Nyāya. Yet the thinkers had distinct historical periods, philosophical commitments, and methods. Their common willingness to question does not amount to identical conclusions, still less to proof of Burhba's supernatural existence. The names give Viśvanāth a respectable intellectual lineage within the novel. Any literal historical equivalence between their philosophies and his position would require additional texts and arguments.

A Change in Power between Questioner and Teacher

The song's proposition that "one who asks does not defeat the teacher, but awakens him" risks determining the meaning of the debate in advance. Questions sometimes improve teachers, but can also show that their claims

are wrong. In the events narrated here Burhba welcomes inquiry and Viśvanāth returns to the game. There is more visible change in the student's conduct than in the teacher's doctrine. Which of Burhba's previous beliefs has been corrected by the exchange? What new conclusion does he explicitly revise? No detailed example is given. The announced triumph of questioning is therefore more extensive in the title and song than in any clear philosophical revision by the teacher.

Several Months Later: A Renewed Threat to Livestock

Some months pass, and animals begin disappearing near a remote, unnamed stretch of the Kamalā-Balān, recalling the period of Sonmā the fisherwoman. "Once again" links an old danger to the current debate. What is established is the disappearance of livestock, not its cause. The number and identity of animals, the time of loss, remains of bodies, and sightings of an attacker are unspecified. The narrator also notes that kabaddi has become irregular and offerings less frequent. Their temporal coexistence heightens apprehension but does not demonstrate necessary causation. Competing possible causes must remain open unless observed and tested.

Events Following One Another Do Not Prove a Cause

Viśvanāth's dissent reduces participation; months later animals disappear. The narrative invites the temptation to conclude that the first event caused the second. In a Navya-Nyāya formulation the pakṣa is livestock loss; the proposed sādhya is that an offended original crocodile attacked because kabaddi weakened; the stated hetu is reduced ritual observance followed by loss. No invariable vyāpti connects them. Predation by other animals, theft, disease, floods, or deliberate human injury remain possible hypotheses; none should be declared established either. The folk narrative may carry meaning within its fictional world, but evidentiary analysis must not convert mere sequence into proven explanation.

Viśvanāth Goes into the Forest: Doubt Becomes Action

Instead of merely declaring a theory to other youths, Viśvanāth visits the river and forest to look for an alternative cause. His dissent thus takes the form of a responsible investigation. Yet there is little procedural detail. Did anyone accompany him? What tools did he carry? Which trail or remains did he follow? Did he measure the marks or return to observe them again? The story does not say. The search is intellectually appropriate as a beginning, but is not presented as a reproducible field investigation with examined alternatives and recorded observations.

Wolves, Thieves, Natural Disaster: A Set of Hypotheses

Viśvanāth considers ordinary possibilities such as wolves, thieves, or natural causes. Proposing a hypothesis and disproving it are two different acts. The source shows no examination of a thief's tracks, patterns of animal predation, or rainfall records. His discovery of a strange mark changes his confidence in familiar explanations, but it does not demonstrate the impossibility of all ordinary causes. Even if a peculiar track were found in one place, additional evidence would be needed to connect it to every livestock disappearance. The novel gives a literary image of investigation, not a comprehensive scientific enquiry.

A Mark by the Water: Observation versus Interpretation

Viśvanāth sees a "large, strange mark" beside the water, unlike those of animals familiar to him. This is the chapter's most concrete new physical sign. The mark is described as perceived within the story; its maker, species, and age remain unknown. Strangeness does not establish supernatural origin. An unfamiliar animal, overlapping tracks, distortion by mud and water, or another natural process are alternatives worth testing rather than facts to be inserted into the narrative. The mark recalls the earlier Sonmā episodes, intensifying the philosophical problem without solving it.

The Evidentiary Limit of "Unfamiliar"

When the narrator says that the track cannot be explained by any "familiar animal," the adjective limits the claim to the observer's available knowledge. Viśvanāth studied logic and mathematics for two years; he is not said to have specialised in zoology or the classification of tracks. A mark outside his familiar categories presents a genuine problem for his understanding, but is not an inventory proving that no natural species could have made it. Maintaining the distinction makes the chapter's intellectual conflict more precise: the possible world of Burhba's folklore remains open, but the failure of one observer to identify a mark is not decisive evidence for that folklore.

The Return of Fear: The Collapse of Reason or Reconsideration?

Viśvanāth returns frightened, and his intellectual confidence has been shaken. Fear is a narrative and affective response, not a logically necessary conclusion. An educated investigator confronted by an unfamiliar phenomenon may reasonably reconsider an earlier opinion, formulate new questions, repeat the inspection, or ask for expert assistance. The chapter instead sends him to the peepal almost immediately. His reaction is psychologically plausible as a mixture of fear and concern for his community. It does not amount to the experimental refutation of rational

inquiry. This distinction is essential to assessing the title's promise of a "rebellion of reason."

Direct Address to an Invisible Burhba

Returned from the forest, Viśvanāth addresses Burhba at the peepal. He admits that he cannot see him but has the sense of speaking to someone who may be listening. Earlier he questioned Burhba's very existence. The scene still does not provide independent visual confirmation; rather, a character speaks toward an invisible listener and receives an answer within the fictional narrative. Whether Viśvanāth hears that answer in the same manner as the hereditary listeners remains insufficiently explained. The episode should therefore be compared with the exceptional opening of Burhba's voice to Yādavānanda in Chapter –78. A narrative's supernatural communication conventions and evidence for actual historical entities are different matters.

Burhba's Reply: Refusing to Demand Blind Belief

Burhba does not demand unconditional belief. He asks Viśvanāth to acknowledge honestly what he has seen and decide for himself. This is a meaningful ethical response by an apparent guardian of tradition. Yet Burhba's formulation can still become a false binary: either kabaddi is superstition or it represents a system the rationalist has not yet understood. A third possibility is that kabaddi has genuine cultural or psychological value without causing the livestock losses; another is that the tracks remain unexplained while the ritual's effectiveness is also unproved. Allowing questions is not identical to allowing the full range of possible answers. The chapter resists dogmatism but does not give reason a completely open field.

Viśvanāth's Changed Statement: Not Complete Faith

Viśvanāth now says he does not fully understand what has happened but will continue to respect the tradition until he finds a better answer. This changes his practical decision from "I no longer believe in this game." Yet it does not prove that all his intellectual doubts have disappeared. He does not declare the existence of Burhba or the original crocodile conclusively established. He accepts participation under uncertainty as a possibly prudent communal practice. His phrase "until I find a better answer" also leaves a conditional route to further change. Reading his return as blind devotion, absolute surrender of reason, or scientific defeat would misrepresent the source.

The Precautionary Principle: Preventive Action without Conclusive Proof

His decision contains a practical thought: if a custom might carry a significant benefit and its cost is low, continuing it while investigating may be reasonable. Yet a sound comparison would require assessment of the custom's costs, risks, alternatives, and actual effect. In Chapter –81 children played kabaddi in front of soldiers, potentially placing themselves in great danger. Preventive action is not harmless in every circumstance. Nor does the present chapter separately demonstrate that renewed performance prevents further animal disappearances. Respectful precaution is thus an ethically interesting proposition, not an experimentally proved causal result.

The Grandmother Is "Not Fully Satisfied": Difference Survives

The original explicitly records that the grandmother is "not fully satisfied" with Viśvanāth's answer. This small qualification prevents artificial unanimity. The older guardian may desire complete belief; the younger man offers participation while reserving doubt. They may cooperate publicly while holding different convictions. This is an important account of social unity without intellectual uniformity. Her inward reflections and further responses, however, remain slight. The continuing disagreement is established, but not richly developed. The community has not resolved its debate merely because the younger man returns to the field.

Burhba's Distinction between Faith and Respect

Burhba says faith and respect are not identical, although they can sometimes produce the same act. Faith concerns belief in a proposition or agency; respect concerns conduct toward people and their inherited practice. Someone can honour a community's mourning and the names of its dead without accepting every supernatural causal claim. Outwardly similar action does not establish identical inward belief. Viśvanāth's turn in kabaddi is direct evidence of cooperation, not full conversion. The distinction grants the chapter a partial escape from the demand for doctrinal conformity.

Returning Together: Other Young People Rejoin

Viśvanāth brings some other young people back to the game. Initially his criticism reduced participation; now he becomes a means of renewed participation. The story shows that individual conduct can affect the community in opposite directions. But it gives no subsequent measure of whether livestock losses ceased, whether the peculiar tracks reappeared, or whether a programme of practical protection was created. Communal

reunion is the immediate result, not a verified end to the physical danger. "Society came together" and "the natural threat was controlled" cannot be treated as synonymous.

The Song and the Ending: Claiming a Victory for Curiosity

The final song praises those who ask questions: "Those who merely repeated forgot; those who asked understood," and "A question is a lamp." The events, however, have not produced a decisive scientific explanation. Viśvanāth accepts uncertainty and returns to participation. The word "understood" is therefore best read as an acknowledgment of the ethical value of questioning rather than as a claim to have identified the cause of animal loss. The metaphor of "Gaṅgeśa's seed" gestures toward future intellectual inquiry in the Navya-Nyāya tradition. It does not establish that Viśvanāth himself became the historical Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya or a verifiable ancestor of his philosophical texts. The song honours curiosity; it is not a final empirical report.

Narratorial Focalisation and the Distribution of Information

The third-person narrator opens with broad knowledge of the school across generations. Viśvanāth's concerns then emerge through dialogue with his grandmother, whose testimony gives the reader a different, inherited form of knowledge. Burhba's assertion that he knows "one thing" creates a deliberate withholding of information. The narrator reports the subsequent animal losses without identifying their cause. The forest scene then approaches Viśvanāth's limited observation closely, especially in its assertion that no familiar animal explains the mark. Finally Burhba's words offer a further interpretation. The narrator uses unequal access to information to produce suspense, while no independent investigator tests the track in the sequence shown.

Indian Poetics: Fearful Wonder, Courage, and the Prospect of Śānta

The new-moon scene initially generates the quieter psychological tension of doubt rather than an immediate spectacle of terror. The mark in the forest combines bhayānaka and adbhuta. Viśvanāth's decision to investigate is a moment of intellectual courage; his frightened return is humanly comprehensible. Burhba's patience, the grandmother's partial acceptance, and continued respectful participation suggest a possible śānta response, even while the actual cause of loss remains unclear. The celebratory song declares an ethical victory for questioning, but provides no answer to the material threat. Such unresolved tension is artistically useful; it should not be obscured by treating adbhuta as evidentiary proof.

Social Knowledge and the Institutional Use of Ritual

Viśvanāth's questioning has two social consequences. First, young people demonstrate that their consent to a ritual can be withdrawn. That is a democratic benefit of the new education. Second, the communal crisis makes them reconsider how to cooperate in protecting their settlement. Even without supernatural efficacy, a rite may supply a setting for shared remembrance, vigilance, and social cohesion. Nevertheless the chapter does not describe practical measures such as livestock guards, secure shelters, recorded losses, inspected riverbanks, or measured tracks. If education has expanded opportunities for reason and science, why has the community not also developed a more systematic inquiry into animal loss? The text does not answer. Its immediate resolution is cooperation; investigation of the physical problem remains incomplete.

Table of Events, Evidence, and Conclusions

Event or stage	Direct outcome in the original	Unresolved claim
School over three generations	Young people learn reading, counting, and questioning	Equal literacy throughout the village untested
Viśvanāth's two years in town	Exposure to logic and mathematics	Particular books and methods unnamed
Standing aside at the new moon	Voluntary withdrawal from participation	Does not establish the ritual's falsity
Grandmother's testimony of sight and hearing	Witness statement across generations	No direct contemporary retesting
Young people decline their turn	Crowd and regularity reportedly diminish	Not a boycott by the entire village
Burhba accepts questioning	Grants ethical legitimacy to an opponent	Full nature of hidden knowledge unrevealed
Livestock disappear some months later	A new socioeconomic crisis	Cause, number, and timespan unclear
Alternative suggestions of wolves or thieves	Viśvanāth goes out to investigate	Neither explanation ruled out conclusively
Unfamiliar mark near the water	The observer's known categories are questioned	Not proven to be a crocodile's footprint
Burhba speaks near the peepal	Viśvanāth acknowledges uncertainty	No external historical evidence of supernatural existence
Viśvanāth returns conditionally	Some young people rejoin	Neither complete faith nor a scientific explanation
Grandmother remains partly unsatisfied	Difference of opinion coexists with public cooperation	No complete ethical consensus
Final song	Questioning receives cultural standing	The text does not establish that the teacher changed his doctrine

Register of Verified Source Quotations

1. “One who asked a question did not defeat the teacher; he awakened him” — opening proverb.

2. “Mandākinī’s school flourished for three generations” — temporal extension.

3. “Mandākinī’s great-grandson, named Viśvanāth” — genealogical identification.

4. “He had spent two years” — duration of study in town.

5. “Viśvanāth did not take part in the game” — public expression of disagreement.

6. “I no longer believe in this game” — original doubt.

7. “It is a beautiful tradition” — distinction between value and belief.

8. “Human memory can be deceptive” — objection to inherited testimony.

9. “With my own eyes, with my own reason” — demand for evidentiary autonomy.

10. “Stopped taking part in kabaddi” — behavioural consequence among youths.

11. “Let him come” — Burhba’s welcome to questioning.

12. “Viśvanāth is not wrong” — acknowledgement of dissent.

13. “Livestock began to disappear” — renewed crisis.

14. “Some ordinary, rational cause” — search for alternatives.

15. “A large, strange mark” — observation in the forest.

16. “I cannot see you” — inability to verify visually.

17. “I will not ask you to believe in me blindly” — refusal to compel faith.

18. “I do not fully understand it” — conditional limit of knowledge.

19. “Until I find a better answer” — provisional duration of the decision.

20. “Faith and respect are not the same thing” — Burhba’s final distinction.

21. “Those who merely repeated forgot; those who asked understood” — the song’s praise of inquiry.

22. “Whoever learned to ask became Gaṅgeśa’s seed” — metaphor of future philosophical questioning.

These excerpts belong to the original prose, dialogue, proverb, and song of Chapter –75. The printed chapter range, 217–220, identifies the chapter as a whole; no unverified exact page has been assigned to an individual quotation.

Critical Achievements, Weaknesses, and Conclusion

The foremost achievement of "Reason's First Rebellion" is that it does not criminalise the questions of a newly educated generation. Viśvanāth belongs to a family of ritual custodians but may refuse to participate, question his grandmother's evidence, and inspect the forest. Burhba respects his right to ask, and the outcome is conditional respect rather than compulsory assent. At this level, the chapter offers a coexistence of intellectual freedom and communal cooperation. Its intellectual limits nevertheless remain substantive. The juxtaposition of reduced ritual observance and missing livestock is not a demonstrated causal relation; an unfamiliar track does not establish an extraordinary crocodile; the investigation is underdeveloped; and the teacher's supposed awakening is less explicit in the events than in the song. The result is twofold: social tension diminishes while the epistemic dispute remains open. That openness can become one of the novel's strengths if subsequent chapters continue to grant the independent questioner a full opportunity for examination.

Textual Basis, Evidentiary Limits, and the Next Section

Primary source: Gajendra Thakur, Gohi Sabhak Beech Jalsamadhi, complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter –75, "Tarkak Pahil Vidroh," printed pages 217–220 according to the contents. The corresponding analytical entry in the original-Maithili-manuscript survey records 856 word units and 64.0 per cent action-indicating paragraphs; this is not itself a verified measure of event density. The post-chapter discussion "Intergenerational Conflict between Tradition and Rationality" is explanatory paratext, not independent material evidence. The final scene shows Viśvanāth's respectful return to kabaddi but gives no biological or physical solution to the disappearance of livestock. The next original chapter, –74, "The Tree's Illness," turns to Kedār's treatment of a tree, the work of communal care, and the material basis of Burhba's refuge.

Critical Section 27 | Original Chapter −74 — The Tree's Illness

Textual Basis, Delimitation, and the Method of Ecological Examination

"The Tree's Illness" is the twenty-seventh independent chapter of the pre-narrative period. The narrative proper moves from its opening proverbial couplet through Kedār's observations, Burhbā's admission of dependence, the community's apprehension, the arrival of an urban tree physician, combined treatment, the children's daily record-keeping, month-by-month recovery, Burhbā's acknowledgment of his own condition, and the institution of annual and intergenerational responsibility for care. The post-chapter commentary, "The Responsibility of Caring for a Living Memorial," constitutes a separate paratext; its general propositions require independent examination. The chapter's illness as represented within the fictional world, a character's diagnosis, the outcome of combined treatments, and the language of symbolism must therefore be kept in four distinct evidentiary categories.

From the Debate in −75 to Ecological Work in −74

In Chapter −75 Viśvanāth questioned the supernatural explanation of the old kabaddi ritual, saw unfamiliar tracks in the forest, and agreed to respect a public tradition provisionally until fuller knowledge became available. In the present chapter his grandson Kedār does not merely repeat the conflict between reason and reverence in speech: he seeks an answer to visible disease through the practical activity of treatment. The significance of this transition is that asking questions becomes a method of action. Previously, the loss of livestock after a decline in the ritual had produced fear; here the signs of illness on the tree are visible to ordinary observers. Burhbā's extraordinary testimony now depends upon care for tangible roots, bark, and leaves. In −75, reconciliation between reason and tradition remained a proclaimed ideal; in −74, that ideal receives a material scene of labor.

The Two Planes of the Proverb: Botanical Illness and Social Silence

The opening injunction, "Attend to the illness of one leaf, lest it spread through the whole tree," first presents a warning about a local threat to the tree. Its second proposition, that a village's disease likewise begins with one silence, transfers botanical treatment into a moral metaphor for failing to raise questions in society. The comparison has an evident basis in the action: had Kedār remained silent, the early signs might have gone unheeded. Yet infection in a plant and the causes of social conflict are not

identical. To describe a dissenting person or a contrary opinion as a "disease" can give the metaphor an oppressive meaning. Chapter –75 had established the legitimacy of Viśvanāth's dissent. The propriety of the new proverb consequently extends to "do not conceal a problem," not to "cut away disagreement."

Kedār's Introduction: A Subtle Problem of Gendered Form and Identity

The original introduces Kedār as Viśvanāth's grandson—"potā, named Kedār"—yet uses the feminine term rakṣikā, "female guardian," for the successor to the ritual. The masculine indications in "grandson," the name Kedār, and the associated verbal forms do not accord with that feminine designation. This is a small but significant editorial instability. The text supplies no separate explanation of Kedār's gender; criticism must not pretend to resolve the discrepancy by conjecture. The larger intention is nevertheless explicit: responsibility for maintaining the ritual has begun to be entrusted to women and men alike, "on the basis of competence." Consistency in grammatical designation remains important within that inclusive intention. This also shows the necessity of careful control over identifying details in the novel's long genealogical sequence.

Succession Open to Women and Men: Institutional Change in the Tradition

The sequence Sāvitrī–Indumatī–Śāradā–Vasundharā–Kauśalyā–Mandākinī had made female succession a principal axis of earlier chapters. Chapter –74 introduces an explicit new proposition: custodianship of the ritual is now assigned to women and men according to competence. Narratively, the declaration marks a possible movement from automatic hereditary entitlement to selection by aptitude. But the text does not show who judges competence, which abilities count, whether an assembly votes, or whether the decision rests with a particular family. A gap thus remains between equality as declared and selection as practiced. Kedār's combined inheritance of argument and reverence makes him an appropriate character for the change; it does not establish the institutional transparency of the process.

Yellow Leaves on the Northern Branch: First Visual Evidence of Disease

Kedār notices that the leaves on the witness-tree's northern branch have begun to turn yellow. This is the chapter's first directly represented change of condition. In earlier chapters, the tree generally served as a durable site of remembrance; now a particular bodily part displays signs of possible illness. The specification "northern branch" lends the observation spatial

precision and visual credibility. Nevertheless, yellowing alone cannot establish a definite cause of disease: seasonality, nutrition, water conditions, and other biological causes remain possible alternatives. The narrative subsequently adds spots on the bark and an examination by a physician, giving the initial observation fuller context. What is seen and what is inferred from what is seen must be distinguished—a distinction that recalls the novel's early epistemological dispute over shell and silver.

Black, Wet Patches on the Bark: From Color to Cause

The leaves' yellowing is accompanied by "black, wet patches" on the bark. Such descriptive particulars give a tangible observational basis to the crisis; the tree's suffering is not merely symbolic. Even so, dark, damp marks do not themselves prove that insects have established nests inside the bark. The tree physician subsequently reaches this conclusion after an examination as narrated within the fiction. The sequence of evidentiary levels is therefore: visible signs, suspicion of illness, inspection of roots, bark, and leaves, and finally the character's diagnosis. More knowledge becomes available at each stage, but no independent experiment, description of a specimen, or elimination of alternative causes is provided. The scene produces a realist effect without becoming a comprehensive report of plant pathology.

The Tree's Body and Burhbā's Spiritual Body

Burhbā's reply, "I am bound to this tree," establishes an important ontological rule of the fictional world. He compares his condition with the dependence of a human body upon breath. A witness to memory who has inhabited one tree for centuries is neither wholly disembodied nor free of natural processes. This is a significant extension of the novel's magical-realist premise. Yet the precise biological or supernatural mechanism through which insects on one branch weaken Burhbā's voice is not supplied. The metaphorical implication—that a community's institution of memory has a vulnerable material foundation—is powerful; the fully testable causal link between a biological tree and a supernatural witness remains incomplete even within the narrative.

The Weakening Voice: Partial Support for a Relationship

Kedār observes the marks on the tree and, that evening, hears that Burhbā's voice is somewhat weaker. This conjunction suggests a relationship between their conditions. Burhbā himself affirms that dependence. But the simultaneous occurrence of illness and a fading voice does not, by itself, constitute proof of causation; within the story, Burhbā's testimony supplies an additional source. In Chapter –77, his voice weakened because of exhaustion; the present chapter supplies a different

interpretation through the tree's condition. The earlier episode makes it difficult to say that insect damage is the sole conceivable cause of vocal weakness. As a literary device, this plurality of vulnerabilities humanizes the keeper of memory. Evidentially, interpretation must remain sensitive to the particular episode.

"Perhaps Its Life Is Ending": A Character's Fear, Not a Medical Finding

Burhbā says, "Perhaps … perhaps its life is coming to an end." The repeated "perhaps" explicitly registers uncertainty; it is not a categorical prediction of death. He is frightened by the dependency that has sustained his centuries of existence. The tree physician subsequently judges the condition treatable, and the narrator reports that the tree becomes healthy within a year. Burhbā's initial fear is therefore contradicted, or at least deferred, by the story's later outcome. This creates a striking dramatic reversal: the extraordinary witness may see across centuries, yet does not fully understand the possibility of treating his material dwelling. Human expertise challenges the limits of his knowledge.

The Village's Alarm: Collective Dependence and the Structure of Crisis

The villagers ask, "If the tree dies, what will become of Burhbā?" The question is quickly followed by their concern over who will retain their names. Fear moves from an event resembling the witness's death to the possible extinction of the entire institution of remembrance. This echoes the anxiety produced by Burhbā's silence in –77, though here the supposed cause is physical illness rather than emotional exhaustion. The community has already instituted an annual remembrance of Burhbā; nevertheless, it again imagines that all history is dependent upon one person and one tree. If written records, songs, and names transmitted by successive generations are available, why must the tree's death automatically end them all? The narrative does not fully investigate that unresolved institutional dependency.

Kedār's Response: From Questioning to a Practical Alternative

Kedār has inherited both "Viśvanāth's rationality" and "the faith of his grandmothers." The characterization recasts the earlier controversy within a younger person's more integrated outlook. On seeing signs of disease, he does not merely await Burhbā's grace; he brings a tree physician from town. His agency consists not in possessing all answers but in recognizing the appropriate specialist, coordinating available local knowledge, and organizing community labor. He is not presented as an independent expert in plant medicine. This is a comparatively credible

model of social leadership: scientific knowledge need not be concentrated in the miraculous genius of a single character.

The Urban Tree Physician: Authority of Expertise and Evidence

The physician examines the roots, bark, and leaves in detail and diagnoses insects tunnelling into the tree and hollowing it out. Within the novel this is a recognizable activity of human expertise. But the insect species, instruments of inspection, diagnostic method, and validation of the diagnosis are not described. The physician says that the disease is "not incurable," though it requires sustained treatment. This is a prospective professional judgment, later supported by the narrated outcome. No independent botanical study makes it appropriate to use this fictional description as the certain diagnosis of an actual peepal tree. The specialist's arrival supplies the social authority of medical deliberation; its experimental particulars remain undescribed.

Godāvarī's Daughter: Succession to Traditional Knowledge of Soil

A descendant of Sonmā the fisherwoman, Godāvarī's daughter, recommends an older method of tending the soil around the roots, involving herbs and natural oils. The scene extends the novel's ecological knowledge through a female lineage. Sonmā had previously questioned the mystery of the primordial crocodile, Burhbā's patience, and the workings of memory; her descendant now contributes to the tangible care of nature. Crucially, the daughter is not given a personal name. A novel committed to preserving names leaves an important contributor to the tree's survival anonymous. Nor is the separate effect of her proposed treatment observed or tested. The scene's value lies in bringing locally accumulated experience into conversation with specialist knowledge, not in establishing its scientific efficacy without further evidence.

Modern and Traditional Knowledge: The Virtue of a Combined Approach

The urban physician prescribes treatment against insects; Godāvarī's daughter recommends herbs, oils, and work on the soil; children keep daily records; and the village settlements provide labor. Four kinds of cooperation appear: specialist diagnosis, local experience, written observation, and collective work. The novel does not insist that one tradition of knowledge is the other's final replacement; it privileges joint action. That is socially valuable, but it makes causal attribution difficult. Which method was applied to which branch, what comparison of results was made, and which harmful practices were rejected are not specified. "Both kinds of knowledge were used and the tree recovered" is a narrative sequence, not a separate measurement of each method's efficacy.

Labor from Every Settlement: The Community at Work

The Charmakār, Brahmin, Kāyastha, and Dhīvar settlements join in protecting the tree. Earlier, the public kabaddi ritual had been an instrument of social gathering; now the shared physical treatment of a living tree becomes collective activity. This is the chapter's significant social innovation: solidarity moves beyond symbolic reverence into the distribution of work. Yet the exact responsibility, hours of labor, decision-making powers, equipment, rest, and expenses of each settlement are not detailed. "All" is a simplifying inclusive expression of the narrator. A year of cooperation does not prove the permanent abolition of caste inequalities; working together in crisis offers an opportunity to change relations, rather than proof that every structural difference has disappeared.

Children's Daily Health Records: An Outcome of Education in −76

The children educated at the coconut-leaf school record the condition of the tree's branches each day—which are improving and where problems remain. Literacy thereby acquires a purpose beyond preserving the past of a ritual: it supports continuing observation of a living environment. In −76 the process began with the making of a letter on a leaf; in −75 an educated young man exercised the right to question; in −74 children's writing becomes a means of reviewing treatment. This three-chapter progression is a major accomplishment in narrative construction. Nevertheless, the record-keeping is not described in terms of dates, branch locations, color measurements, treatment quantities, comparative results, or re-examination by the physician. Keeping records is part of the text; complete scientific standardization is not.

Soil, Root, Bark, and Leaf: An Environmental Narrative Space

Earlier the waters of the river and pond formed the crocodile's region of influence; here the peepal's roots, the surrounding soil, its bark, and its leaves become active narrative sites. The nonhuman tree is no longer only a stationary memorial: it becomes ill, exhibits symptoms, and redirects collective human labor. The movement from one northern branch to the work of an entire village gives the narrative a spatial expansion from the minute to the social. On the other hand, drainage, soil structure, light on the branch, seasonal heat, and the insect's ecological causes are not specified. The chapter accordingly gains material immediacy without offering a complete account of an ecosystem.

The Evidentiary Status of the Insect Diagnosis

The physician attributes the decay to insects, but the description supplies neither an independently tested sample nor a direct account of the insects

observed through a particular method. What the reader has is a diagnosis made by a character on the basis of an examination of the tree's visible condition. Other contributing factors—the state of the soil, the age of branches, weather, or additional diseases—are not discussed. Such silence matters because the environmental politics of the novel should not be compressed into a formula of one disease and one cure. The insects serve as the immediate focus of the literary crisis. Determining a biological diagnosis and verifying the efficacy of a treatment would be different undertakings.

"Not Incurable": The Specialist's Qualified Reassurance

The tree physician initially says the condition is not incurable, but calls for patience and continuous care. The qualification gives treatment a duration and a demand for work. Set against Burhbā's fear that the tree's life may be over, it introduces the possibility of hope. "Not incurable," however, is not a guarantee of recovery; the result must depend upon the severity of the condition and response to care. Within a year, the novel tells us, the tree becomes healthy, and so the physician's expectation succeeds within the fiction. His prognosis, the narrator's subsequent report of an outcome, and medical advice for a reader's real-life tree remain separate kinds of statement.

A Combined Causal Sequence: The Effect of Each Component Unmeasured

The tree improves while the physician's anti-insect treatment, herbal and oil-based applications, attention to soil, labor from the Charmakār, Dhīvar, Brahmin, and Kāyastha settlements, and children's records proceed together. In Navya-Nyāya's inquiry into causes, this joint outcome cannot establish any one factor as a sufficient cause. If the sādhya is the tree's recovery, numerous cooperating conditions are present, none tested in isolation. Both "traditional oil alone saved it" and "modern treatment alone saved it" would exaggerate what is known. The literary success lies in demonstrating the significance of collective work, not in proving the pharmaceutical power of an individual remedy. The novel presents the coexistence of different knowledges in practice, not a controlled therapeutic experiment.

Month-by-Month Improvement: Ecological Duration

The narrator describes the tree's recovery as proceeding "month by month." This expression prevents the treatment from becoming a miracle accomplished in a single night; it signifies sustained labor. In –77, Burhbā's silence received an emotionally immediate resolution over one night. In –74, physical healing requires months. The longer duration

increases the realism of the environmental narrative. But the actual measurements in the daily records, days of failure, recurring infection, and alterations in treatment are not dramatized. “Month by month” supplies a sense of time rather than a fully detailed ecological investigation. Because the tree is alive, its changes do not obey a character's instant wish: the distinction gives its nonhuman agency particular importance.

“Completely Healthy” Within a Year: The Narrator's Outcome

The original says that within a year the tree became entirely healthy and its leaves turned deep green again. This is the outcome as stated within the fiction. Its directly described visible sign is renewed greenness, together with the narrator's wider assertion of complete health; no long-term diagnostic account of roots and bark follows. “Completely healthy” is a compressed word of literary resolution, not a certificate issued under medical standards. The narrated success is attributed to the community's human care rather than an independent act of Burhbā's magic. Nevertheless, environmental or seasonal factors may also have affected the year's changes; the novelist does not investigate them. Recognizing this limit leaves intact the chapter's strong representation of human ecological responsibility.

Burhbā's Experience of Weakness: A Philosophy of Embodiment

During treatment, Burhbā experiences weakness and feels that the assistance offered by every hand in the village reaches him. This differs from the emotional exhaustion of –77. Here the supernatural witness confronts the deterioration of the material basis of his existence. He had long taught that no body is immortal; he must now apply this teaching to himself. The reversal is intellectually important: a witness who knew that other lives were bounded by time acquires knowledge of his own embodied dependence through experience. The work brings supernatural existence closer to material vulnerability while leaving the question of Burhbā's eventual death—and the biological limits of the tree's life—open.

“A Long, Fragile Thread”: A New Metaphor for Witnessing

Burhbā calls his testimony “a long, fragile thread.” Length and breakability coexist in the metaphor. Centuries of witnessing are not an indestructible possession but a relationship sustained by interdependent elements. The thread binds leaves, roots, voice, names, children's written records, and public care within one symbolic sequence. Yet recognizing fragility does not create a complete institutional alternative. If the peepal really dies, through what medium will Burhbā's memory of names continue? How independent are the written books, kabaddi, and the

school? The chapter does not answer this double question of dependency. Thus the image's beauty is accompanied by an enduring existential anxiety.

The Living Memorial: A Dynamic Site of Remembrance

The peepal is not an immobile stone statue. It is a living organism that can become diseased, change, and respond to seasons. The conception of a "living memorial" is therefore striking: preservation requires continuous biological care, not mere veneration or the repairs given to an archaeological object. By producing yellow leaves and marked bark, the tree redirects the villagers' actions. Nonhuman agency here is not simply a figure of speech in which a tree "speaks"; it consists of a tree's bodily state and the social consequences of that condition. Nevertheless, the tree's independent ecological interests and the community's desire to use it as a house of memory are not necessarily identical. To value it solely as Burhbā's memorial could subordinate the plant's life to human purposes. The chapter's final insistence that the tree must be "allowed to live" moves partly beyond that instrumental attitude.

The Age of the Peepal: Limits of the Fiction's Twelve-Hundred-Year Claim

Over the novel's immense pre-narrative chronology, the peepal is presented as a witness-tree that has lived for centuries. This chapter likewise says it has accompanied Burhbā over hundreds of years. These are temporal propositions within the fictional world, not independently established botanical age measurements. If the "twelve hundred years" invoked elsewhere and the tree of this chapter belong to one continuous living organism, the novel is imagining an extraordinarily long life. Magical realism can make such an age part of its invented world; a realistic botanical history cannot acquire independent validation from it. Internal symbolism, narrated event, and external natural history must be held on distinct planes.

Children's Writing Across Time: From Daily Records to Communal Practice

Every day the coconut-leaf-school pupils record the tree's condition. This writing holds the promise of a long ecological memory: when the illness began, when treatment was applied, and when the leaves became green again. But the medium of the records, the preservation of pages, adult verification, and access by later generations are not described. The school of writing on leaves becomes a school of caring for a tree. Literacy no longer means only the recitation of the past contained in a book; it may supply observation for decisions in the present. The incompleteness of

record-keeping methods does not cancel that achievement. It identifies a possible direction for the institution's further development.

The Cost of Treatment, Labor, and Resources: An Absent Social Account

The village summons a physician from town and assembles herbal preparations, natural oil, labor, and the means of daily recording. The narrative offers no account of the economic cost, the physician's fee, the journey, the production of oil, the effect on workers' livelihoods, or unequal contributions. The broad assertion that all settlements joined in presents ideal social unity; it does not show whether the burden of unpaid work fell disproportionately on marginal communities. In the approach of Videha Parallel History, making labor visible is not enough: its distribution and recognition matter as well. A call to duty does not automatically eliminate the poor person's economic constraints. Scenes of dividing work, debating expensive treatments, or obtaining consent from poor families could have made the social result more credible.

River, Soil, and Vegetation: Interconnections of Water and Life

There is no direct scene in this chapter of a river flooding, of a crocodile, or of a battle over a pond. The principal physical materials are the peepal's roots, soil, bark, leaves, and oil. Aquatic ecology may supply an indirect background in the soil's moisture and the tree's life, but the text offers no experimental account of moisture. Criticism must not invent events under the generic heading of "watery imagery." This is more specifically a crisis of arboreal ecology; it connects the later story of water burial to a natural system supporting its institution of witnesses. Compared with the fear of river and crocodile, the illness of roots and bark is more visible and more susceptible to human intervention.

An Internal Tension in Treatment: Cutting Disease or Saving the Tree?

The concluding song says, "If one leaf turns black, cut it off at once." Within the story, the physician seeks to destroy the insects without harming the tree. Read literally as botanical instruction, the song could be inconsistent: prompt removal of an infected leaf is not necessarily appropriate for every condition, and the chapter supplies no scientific proof that it is. Read figuratively, it urges recognition of a problem early and decisive action against neglect. In society, however, the metaphor of "cutting off a black leaf" might also authorize exclusion. Chapter –75 affirmed the importance of keeping a dissenting questioner within the community. The lyric must not be converted into either a literal

prescription for plant care or a policy of removing those who think differently.

Concealing and Revealing Disease: The Politics of Silence

The lyric "The illness concealed spread; the illness brought to light was checked" proposes a moral principle of transparency. Kedār did not hide the first signs; Burhbā admitted weakness; the physician made the diagnosis public; the children wrote down the condition day by day. These four actions give the analogy a narrative basis. Revelation alone, however, does not arrest disease: treatment, ecological change, and time are also required. Disclosure may be necessary in the social metaphor without being sufficient. Such differentiation does not weaken the lyric's ethical purpose; it gives the injunction a proportionate relationship to real action.

Narrator, Focalisation, and the Distribution of Information

The beginning stays close to Kedār's inspection. His observed signs and Burhbā's weakened voice generate the suspicion of illness. Burhbā's dialogue exposes the limits of his self-knowledge. With the physician's arrival, a professional focal perspective enters; Godāvarī's daughter contributes a voice of local practice; children's records indicate observation by multiple people. Finally, the narrator surveys a year's treatment and the duty of "every generation" through an apparently omniscient summary. Focalisation thus moves among different agents, but some of them—especially the unnamed female healer and the children—receive no extended independent dialogue. The declared polyphony is broader than the dialogue actually dramatized.

Narrative Duration: From One Evening's Fear to a Year's Recovery

Kedār's observation and Burhbā's weakened voice constitute the dramatic scene of an evening. The examination and organized treatment receive comparatively brief scenes; improvement "month by month" becomes an extended summary, complete recovery "within a year" its conclusion, and generational duties a subsequent iterative declaration. This allocation of narrative time deserves attention. The slow course of illness does not receive a scene for every change; instead, Burhbā's admission of weakness interrupts the process to form the moral climax. This compression preserves the large novel's temporal sweep but reduces the lived detail of failures or recurrences during treatment.

Indian Poetics: The Terrible, the Compassionate, the Marvellous, and the Tranquil

The yellow leaves and blackened marks first generate apprehension of decay, with an element of bhayānaka. Burhbā's frail fear that life may be

ending becomes a source of karuṇa. The physician's practical help, the hereditary woman's local knowledge, and the villagers' cooperation produce the affective energy of shared effort; the deep-green leaves at year's end allow a sense of śānta. The specifically marvellous element is the ontological relation between Burhbā and the tree, not the appearance of insects or disease by itself. Through dhvani, the "long, fragile thread" suggests the vulnerability of memory, "one leaf" local vigilance, and "allow the tree to live" a newly recognized biological claim. The demand of aucitya requires attention to the danger of treating "cut off the black leaf" as a rigorous medical or social command.

Videha Parallel History: An Unnamed Healer and Children's Observation

The novel undertakes to preserve the memory of people excluded from prestigious histories. In this section, a female descendant of Sonmā the fisherwoman offers knowledge that helps save the central tree, yet her personal name is absent. The pupils write daily care records, yet no individual child is identified. The irony is clear: the actual contributors to saving a tree dedicated to remembrance remain nameless while Kedār and Burhbā receive extended dialogue. The method of Parallel History demands that such unseen work be brought into focus on the evidence available. To invent names for the helpers would violate fidelity to the source; the appropriate task is to acknowledge their anonymity and its social meaning.

Limits of Environmental Ethics: Reverence Is Not Enough

The village's concluding saying declares: "Service to Burhbā means not only saving names, but also allowing the tree to live." This is the chapter's clearest ethical gain. Caring for a living cultural witness requires treatment, observation, cleaning, and protection appropriate to the seasons. The story establishes that veneration without material care is insufficient. Yet its described regimen cannot be applied without examination as a universal treatment for old trees. Different species, conditions, and environments require different expertise. In its literary sense, "allow it to live" appeals for heritage to be respected as a living natural relation rather than turned into an inert museum object.

Event, Evidence, and Outcome: A Four-Column Critical Account

Event or observation	Direct evidence in the original	Unresolved cause or evidentiary limit	Communal or ethical consequence
Kedār's initial observation	Yellow leaves on the northern branch	No definite cause of disease	Personal responsibility for identifying a crisis

Event or observation	Direct evidence in the original	Unresolved cause or evidentiary limit	Communal or ethical consequence
Dark wet marks on the bark	Described visible sign	No independent test for a specific insect or infection	Concern over Burhba's bodily dependence
Burhba's weakening voice	"I am bound to this tree"	Biological-supernatural mechanism undefined	Material fragility of the witness exposed
Alarm in the community	Fear that tree and Burhba may die	Other ways of preserving names remain possible	Dependence of memory upon one tree
Kedār fetches a physician	Tree specialist summoned from town	Cost and journey not described	Practical leadership grows from questioning
Examination of root, bark, and leaf	Physician's "close inspection"	Testing procedure unspecified	Human expertise enters the scene
Diagnosis of insects	Physician claims they are making it hollow	No identification or verification of species or samples	One proposed cause guiding treatment
Godāvarī's daughter's knowledge	Herbal, natural-oil, and soil treatments	Separate efficacy untested; the woman unnamed	Local female knowledge used without recognition
Labour from every village quarter	Leatherworkers, Brahmins, Kāyasthas, and fishers cooperate	Allocation and cost of labour undescribed	Symbolic unity becomes material cooperation
Students' daily log	Health records of the branches	Measurements lack a stated standard	Environmental application of literacy
Improvement month by month	Gradual recovery is narrated	The separate effect of each treatment unknown	Importance of long-term care
Burhba acknowledges weakness	"A long, fragile thread"	Full rule of biological dependence unknown	Revision of a claim to immortality
Green leaves within a year	Narrator declares complete recovery	No long-term clinical corroboration	Narrative success of communal hope and labour
Rules for preservation across generations	Cleaning roots, checking insects, seasonal protection	No institutional fund or safety archive	Ecological civic responsibility
Warning in the closing song	"Conceal the disease" and "cut away a black leaf"	Not literal medical or social rules	Caution against neglect; risk of exclusion as metaphor

Original Chapter −74: Verified Index of Textual Evidence

1. "Attend to the illness of one leaf, lest it spread through the whole tree"—opening proverbial warning; Chapter −74.

2. "The village's illness too begins with one silence"—social metaphor; Chapter −74.

3. "Viśvanāth's grandson, named Kedār"—genealogical identification; Chapter −74.

4. "Became the female guardian of the ritual"—inconsistent gendered form; Chapter −74.

5. “On the basis of competence”—new rule of succession; Chapter –74.

6. “The leaves on the northern branch were turning yellow”—visible symptom; Chapter –74.

7. “Black, wet patches”—condition of the bark; Chapter –74.

8. “Your tree seems ill”—Kedār's question; Chapter –74.

9. “I am bound to this tree”—Burhbā's admitted dependence; Chapter –74.

10. “As your body is bound to your breath”—analogy of embodiment; Chapter –74.

11. “Perhaps … perhaps its life is coming to an end”—uncertain fear of death; Chapter –74.

12. “If the tree dies”—communal apprehension; Chapter –74.

13. “Viśvanāth's rationality”—inheritance of questioning; Chapter –74.

14. “The faith of the grandmothers”—inheritance of belief; Chapter –74.

15. “Tree physician”—arrival of professional expertise; Chapter –74.

16. “Close examination of roots, bark, and leaves”—the reported inspection; Chapter –74.

17. “Prey to various kinds of insects”—the diagnosis; Chapter –74.

18. “This is not incurable”—possibility of treatment; Chapter –74.

19. “It requires patience and continuous care”—duration of treatment; Chapter –74.

20. “Charmakār, Brahmin, Kāyastha, Dhīvar”—cooperation across settlements; Chapter –74.

21. “Godāvarī's daughter”—unnamed female bearer of knowledge; Chapter –74.

22. “Herbs”—local substance; Chapter –74.

23. “Natural oils”—local treatment; Chapter –74.

24. “A daily record of the tree's health”—the pupils' written observations; Chapter –74.

25. “Month by month”—extension of duration; Chapter –74.

26. “A long, fragile thread”—metaphor of perishable witnessing; Chapter –74.

27. “Within one year”—compressed period of recovery; Chapter –74.

28. “The tree became completely healthy”—the narrator's outcome; Chapter −74.

29. “Cleaning the roots, checking for insects”—annual duties of care; Chapter −74.

30. “Not only saving names, but allowing the tree to live”—the village's saying; Chapter −74.

31. “If one leaf turns black, cut it off at once”—symbolic imperative in the song; Chapter −74.

32. “The illness concealed spread; the illness disclosed was checked”—the final song's ethic of openness; Chapter −74.

These short passages are matched to the original narrative and its closing song. The chapter's subsequent commentary has not been silently merged into the quotation register; no precise page number has been invented for individual extracts.

Overall Critical Judgment: Achievement and Limitations

The central achievement of “The Tree's Illness” is that the novel finally shows the long power of Burhbā's remembrance as dependent upon a living organism vulnerable to illness. A witness of hundreds of years admits weakness, and the village answers with treatment rather than reverence alone. Kedār's summoning of a specialist, locally transmitted knowledge from the line of Sonmā and Godāvarī, cooperation among settlements, and the written observations of coconut-leaf-school pupils together form a coherent scene of shared labor. There is effective causal continuity among education in −76, inquiry in −75, and practical care in −74. Four limitations must nevertheless remain explicit: the diagnosis and independent scientific effectiveness of combined treatments have not been verified; the feminine word for guardian contradicts Kedār's masculine identification as a grandson; Godāvarī's daughter is unnamed, while the distribution and cost of labor are absent; and the song's instruction to cut off a black leaf risks becoming an unquestioning biological or social order. The narrator's “complete recovery” is an outcome within one year of the fiction, not proof of permanent immortality. With this qualification, the novel succeeds notably in transforming the protection of cultural memory into ecological citizenship.

Evidence Protocol, Paratext, and Transition to the Next Chapter

Primary text: Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, Complete Trilogy, Part 0, Chapter −74, “The Tree's Illness,” original combined Word manuscript. “The Responsibility of Caring for a Living Memorial” is a separate interpretive comment following the original

chapter; it provides neither independent pharmaceutical nor historical verification. The present criticism does not turn fictional treatments into instructions for actual tree medicine. The following independent critical study concerns Chapter –73, “Mohan's Melody,” examining flute, grief, the names of the dead, and the musical transformation of collective memory.

Critical Section 28 | Original Chapter −73 — Mohan's Melody

Textual Basis, Chapter Boundaries, and the Critical Undertaking

Chapter −73, "Mohan's Melody," is the twenty-eighth independent chapter of the pre-narrative period. Its opening folk song announces both a social result and a future literary application before the narrated events occur. The narrative proper includes Śīlāvatī's succession as keeper of the ritual, Mohan's drumming, the death of his four-year-old daughter Rādhikā after a fever, the father's weeks of silence, the first grief-stricken beat beneath the peepal, Śīlāvatī's proposal, melodies devised for individual names, Burhbā's ethical response, and a statement concerning the tradition's future. The subsequent note, "The Birth of Art from Grief," clarifies the literary intention but constitutes paratext rather than a further event in the story. Critical reading must distinguish a melody's acoustic construction as actually described, the narrator's assertions about it, and the sounds a reader mentally imagines.

From −74 to −73: Care for a Living Tree Becomes Care for Audible Memory

In "The Tree's Illness," the community gathered the physician's expertise, local remedies, children's written observations, and labor from different settlements to preserve Burhbā's peepal. The vulnerability and treatment of memory's material foundation were central. The present chapter shifts the effort to preserve memory from a fixed place among roots and branches to a sound that exists only momentarily in the air. Allowing a tree to live and keeping a melody alive are different procedures. The first entails the treatment of an existing living organism; the second depends upon performance, attentive listening, and repetition through generations. This is an effective development, because care for a material environment now gives way to an additional sensory medium of collective remembrance. A melody, however, does not have the same tangible continuity as a living tree: its persistence depends on acts of reproduction by people.

Title and Opening Proverb: Sound Vanishing into Air

"The flute's melody mingles with the air, yet the ear keeps it" joins the momentariness of sound to the relatively greater duration of memory. Air transmits music; the ear receives the auditory experience; the mind may retain and reproduce its emotional impression. This is the imaginative proposition of the couplet. The ear is not literally an enduring archive of acoustic waves: recollection, singing, and renewed playing are distinct processes after hearing. Likewise, a melody that "touches the heart" refers

to emotional effect, not physical touch. More importantly, the couplet explicitly mentions a flute, whereas Mohan later plays beats upon a drum. The instrument in the proverb, the imaginative claims of the opening song, and the narrated action cannot automatically be treated as identical.

The Proleptic Folk Song: A Structure That Discloses the Outcome First

The preliminary song already says that Mohan's daughter died, that he abandoned the drum and placed a name within the flute, that the melody entered Śīlāvatī's ritual, and that folk songs would emerge at the opening of future chapters. Only afterward does the narrative return to grief, the composition of music, and the community's decision. The arrangement is not a simple chronological advance. A declared future precedes an explanatory account of its origin. Narratologically, the song functions as proleptic announcement; the subsequent prose partially moves backward to narrate how the announced result came to be. The reader's central question shifts from "What will happen?" to "How did this happen?" The technique gives symbolic density to a long-term cultural outcome, but it also reduces uncertainty about the child's death and Mohan's later achievement by announcing them beforehand.

Śīlāvatī, Kedār's Daughter: A Bearer Who Reworks the Ritual

The narrator says that after Kedār, responsibility for the ritual passed to his daughter Śīlāvatī. In the preceding chapter, Kedār had been introduced as a grandson, while a feminine term was employed for his office; here his daughter Śīlāvatī is clearly identified. She does not simply repeat the inherited public arrangement. Hearing the beat that expresses Mohan's suffering, she proposes joining the name of each deceased person to a distinct melody corresponding to the feeling of that person's life. This is an independent creative proposal by a woman. Its origin lies in the conversation between an artist and a female custodian rather than an order issued by the supernatural male witness. Nevertheless, the actual mode of appointing custodians is still unexplained: the text gives father-to-daughter succession without describing a formal selection procedure.

Drums and Mṛdaṅgas in the Charmakār Settlement: Respect for Occupational Culture

During Śīlāvatī's time, the making of drums and mṛdaṅgas is flourishing in the leatherworkers' settlement. This establishes a material and social background for Mohan's musical identity. Drumming is not merely a private gift: it rests upon obtaining materials, making instruments, cultivating sound, practicing, and transmitting an occupational tradition. People come from distant villages to hear Mohan play, as the narrator

reports. But the chapter does not describe the other makers, the distribution of their work, the sourcing of leather, income, or the caste-bound rules of the market. Videha Parallel History should recognize the prestige of this occupational art while observing the anonymous labor through which it is sustained. Mohan's excellence develops within a social community of skilled work; it is not a miracle that appears from nowhere.

The Seventh Generation from Somar: A Long Genealogy of Remembered Names

Mohan is identified as a seventh-generation descendant of Somar. In the novel's earlier tradition of preserving names, Somar's memory has been one social foundation. The present narrative presents a distant descendant whose special musical skill produces a fresh cultural practice. Genealogy thus becomes more than biological succession: it can connect craft, reputation, and innovation across time. Yet the intermediary names of those seven generations are absent, as is a precise chronology linking Śīlāvatī's lineage with the Somar–Mohan line. “Seventh generation” must be taken as a structural claim by the narrator, not a complete, separately verified genealogical chain. The compression serves the vast novel's historical span but cannot substitute for the details required by an actual pedigree.

Rādhikā at Four: Limits of a Child Character's Life and Representation

Rādhikā, aged four, is Mohan's only daughter mentioned here. The narrator says her father loved her more than life itself. This establishes her emotional importance within the family, but her own play, voice, wishes, character, mother, companions, and experience of daily life are not developed. Her name subsequently becomes the subject of a melody, yet listeners know her chiefly as a child remembered through her father's grief. For a narrative devoted to saving names, the limitation is consequential: the memory of Rādhikā grows immense while Rādhikā herself receives little independent voice. A compressed account of the child's life intensifies the pathos of death, at the cost of much of her individual complexity.

The Fifth Day of Fever: Death and Its Evidentiary Limits

One winter Rādhikā develops a high fever. Śīlāvatī, the village healer, and Mohan attend to her night and day, but on the fifth day she dies in her father's lap. The scene is brief and emotionally concentrated. The text specifies “high fever”; it names neither an infection nor a diagnosis, medication, epidemic, polluted water, or identifiable error of treatment. To supply a particular medical cause would be an unsupported invention. What the fictional event establishes is that death was not averted despite

communal efforts to nurse her, and this experience of futile care gives rise to Mohan's subsequent silence. Burhbā's extraordinary capacity to witness does not save the child either, making the distinction between sustaining a life and preserving its name painfully clear.

A Small Hand Clasping Her Father's Finger: The Final Image of Touch

The death scene says that Rādhikā's "small hand held Mohan's finger." Through a single bodily detail, the child's otherwise scarcely voiced presence becomes acutely palpable. The intimate image is a powerful determinant of karuṇa-rasa. Mohan's later melody feels like a response to the absence of that final touch. But the story gives no conscious final utterance from Rādhikā, no request from her that her father make music, and no choice of an instrument by the child. It would therefore be wrong to call the melody "a memorial chosen by Rādhikā herself." The music is an act of love composed by her father, with his daughter as its subject. Its emotional intensity and the limits of the dead child's self-representation must be acknowledged together.

Weeks of Silence: The Absence of Both Weeping and Music

After Rādhikā's death, Mohan does not touch his drum for many weeks. Neither weeping nor music is heard from his house. The absence of outward activity is itself an event carrying narrative meaning. The villagers are worried, yet none ventures to address him. The silence does not permit a definite clinical diagnosis or prove that all bereaved people follow the same course. It is the response of one specific character to loss. Importantly, his main occupational instrument has fallen silent: grief may thus have interrupted his livelihood as well as his emotional life. The economic consequences, household income, and practical assistance given to the family are omitted.

The Village's Concern: Inability to Speak and the Question of Care

The villagers see Mohan's silence, but "no one gathered the courage to say anything to him." This can signify both sensitivity and inaction. People may fear imposing upon his private suffering; equally, no one is shown asking whether he needs practical help or companionship. During Burhbā's silence in –77, Godāvarī had asked who would listen to the life of the person who listened to everyone else's story. In –73 Mohan himself emerges from silence, while the community does not develop a detailed practice of grief support. This does not mean its members are heartless. It means the narrator is more interested in the transformation of Mohan's inward pain into artistic activity than in the everyday organization of support around him.

The Peepal on the Eve of the New Moon: A Return to Public Memory

One evening, just before the new moon, Mohan picks up his drum and walks to the peepal. The tree has already served as a site for names of the dead, Burhbā's witnessing, illness, and collective care. Mohan leaves the silence of home for that public place, but initially sits without speaking for a long time. The movement of space indicates a journey from private grief toward the possibility of shared remembrance, not yet a completed public performance. The evening before the new moon approaches the time of kabaddi; this timing gives Śīlāvatī's later proposal an appropriate setting. The bereaved man's evening and the ritual night are not naturally identical, but the existing communal calendar provides a place for a new form of music.

From Isolated Beat to Rhythm: The Stages in Sound's Emergence

Mohan begins by striking his drum softly in a grief-laden manner. The beats are irregular at first and gradually form a rhythm. This is the one detailed process of instrumental performance actually described in the chapter. The narrative suggests a distinction between an accomplished tune and a rhythm that develops through playing: sorrow begins as disordered pulsation and acquires an ordered acoustic form. Yet the text supplies no beat-pattern, metric cycle, tempo, phrase structure, pitch contour, playing technique, or independently reproducible notation. The opening song meanwhile points toward another instrument, the flute. Readers may imaginatively hear the emotional shape of the sound, but cannot reconstruct an exact score or recording from the written description.

Between a Lament and a Lullaby: The Sensory Originality of the Composition

The narrator calls the melody neither “entirely a lament” nor “entirely a lullaby,” but something between them. This is where Mohan's art gains individuality beyond generic sad music. Rādhikā was a four-year-old child: the lullaby recalls care and nurture, whereas the lament addresses absence after death. A tune poised between these forms combines the loving past with the bereaved present. This invites an interpretation in terms of mingled rasa or affective transition, but it does not identify a particular rāga or a measurable musical configuration. “Between” is an emotional and comparative description, not a precise proposition concerning intervals or rhythmic meter.

Burhbā Hears and Asks: Experience Before Explanation

Hearing Mohan play, Burhbā calls the melody both "beautiful" and "sad," then asks, "What are you playing?" His centuries of witnessing do not automatically reveal the identity of a new piece of music. To know its particular meaning, he needs the living artist's words. This is an important epistemological moment. Auditory experience enables Burhbā to perceive an affective quality, while Mohan's verbal testimony identifies the connection to Rādhikā. Musical meaning is thus not entirely self-evident or universal: the cultural situation and the composer's intention matter to interpretation. Burhbā's question makes space for imaginative dialogue instead of imposing a ready-made explanation upon the artist.

"Let the Name Be More Than a Word": Mohan's Aesthetic Intention

Mohan says that Burhbā already keeps Rādhikā's name safe, yet he does not want it to remain "just a word." He wishes people hearing it to feel the fullness of love contained in her life. The wish distinguishes the minimal identifying sign of a name from remembrance suffused with felt experience. Melody becomes a medium of emotional recognition. Nevertheless, the factual accuracy of a name and the intensity of a tune do not verify one another. If a listener does not know Rādhikā's story, the sound need not convey the same precise meaning that Mohan intended. The community therefore needs to preserve the spoken name, the associated story, and the circumstances of performance alongside the melody.

Śīlāvatī's Proposal: Private Grief as a Public Practice

Śīlāvatī asks whether, whenever a name is called at the new moon, a short melody might be played to reflect something of the person's life. In this proposal, a father's individual music of mourning becomes a possible component of the communal name-preserving ritual. Mohan initially wants to retain the love surrounding Rādhikā; Śīlāvatī sees how this form could be adapted to a wider range of lives. The practice emerges from their combined creation: an artist makes the music and a custodian imagines its public form. Mohan agrees, but the text does not say what Rādhikā's mother or other close relatives thought about making a family's private grief public. Their absence matters, for Rādhikā was not only the source of an artist's inspiration but an individual member of a household.

A Year of Composition: From Individual Art to Plural Memory

Mohan accepts Śīlāvatī's proposal. During "the following year" he composes short pieces for Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā, and other earlier stories. The year is an important interval of work: his first spontaneous beating of the drum becomes a sustained effort to compose

music attached to particular names. “For every old story” conveys the ambition of inclusiveness, while the narrative names a few representative examples rather than furnishing a complete list of tunes. The dates of work, methods of composition, practice sessions, listeners' responses, and revisions remain abbreviated. The year is a declared period of production within the fiction, not a fully dramatized account of musical craft. Nevertheless, it matters that the tunes are made and performed, not magically timeless from the moment of their conception.

Hulāsā's Melody: An Unfinished Sentence in Musical Form

Hulāsā's melody is described as “tender, incomplete, breaking in the middle,” because her last sentence had broken off. The relationship between the event of a life and an imagined musical form is unusually direct. A tune associated with a particular name interprets that person's emotional narrative. But the chapter does not specify which rhythmic cycle ends abruptly or what acoustic phrase remains unresolved; “incomplete” is a literary account, not reproducible music notation. There is also the risk of reducing Hulāsā's whole life to the rupture of one last sentence. Remembering her should entail more than an accident or unfinished utterance. Whether listeners hear a fuller account of her experiences determines the social meaning of the melody.

Sukhdev's Melody: Waiting and Sudden Silence

Sukhdev's melody is “slow, full of waiting, then suddenly quiet.” Musical movement here translates the temporal experience of a life. Sustained sound or a slow pace may suggest waiting, while abrupt cessation recalls death or an interrupted possibility. Yet the text does not identify a rule making these sounds necessarily equivalent to the details of Sukhdev's biography. A listener unfamiliar with his story could construe the same melody as expressing another sort of sorrow. The example demonstrates the social and conventional making of musical meaning, rather than a universal scientific connection between particular notes and particular emotions.

Ratnā's Melody: A Single Image of Motherhood

Ratnā's melody is characterized as “warm, touching like a mother's heart.” The recognizable affective framework of motherhood immediately suggests tenderness and compassion. But if Ratnā's earlier life, medical-herbal knowledge, and independent intellectual complexity are condensed into the single role of “mother,” much of her character disappears. The novel honors her, yet the tune's symbolic designation may reproduce a conventional gender stereotype. If Śīlāvatī's new musical observance aims to preserve the plurality of excluded lives, it should be attentive to the

danger of making motherhood or pathos the sole defining quality of each woman. The sound may be affectionate, but social history requires a more specific account of a person's life.

Jīvantī's Name Is Included, but Her Melody Is Undescribed

The original explicitly states that Mohan also creates a short tune for Jīvantī. It describes the particular affective characteristics of the music for Hulāsā, Sukhdev, and Ratnā, yet gives no comparable description of Jīvantī's tune. The unequal allocation of attention is visible. The project seeks to give each name a melody, while dramatizing only selected examples. This may follow from the chapter's brevity, but criticism must register the unevenness. The narrator speaks of "every old story"; the evidence supplies specific characteristics for only some of the names. A complete catalog of their separate musical compositions is not presented.

Rādhikā's Melody as a Maṅgalācaraṇa: Entering the Ritual through Grief

Mohan's first tune begins to be performed before every new-moon kabaddi. The narrator calls it "a kind of maṅgalācaraṇa," an auspicious opening. The change is rich in implication: the mourning of one dead child becomes the introductory sign of the entire ritual of preserving names. A maṅgalācaraṇa usually suggests a favorable beginning; here remembrance of grief becomes a condition of communal love. The statement that kabaddi is "not about competition" subordinates the game's sportive character to its ethical purpose. But the text does not show how the community considered alternative choices before making one child's private melody the opening to remembrance of all the dead. The agreement between Śīlāvatī and Mohan receives a subsequent narrative summary of public acceptance.

Name, Melody, and Testimony: Three Media for One Life

Burhbā safeguards Rādhikā's name; Mohan wants to give it audible emotional force; Śīlāvatī makes repeated performance part of a public ritual. These levels serve different purposes: identifying a person, expressing feeling, and arranging communal remembrance. They are not interchangeable instruments of truth. Calling a name is a basic sign of an identifiable life; a melody interprets its emotional significance; kabaddi supplies a public site for collective reenactment. The trilogy thus moves from protection through one voice to a multi-medium conception of memory. Even so, merely hearing a tune does not disclose Rādhikā's specific biographical facts. The brief life story or announcement of a name must continue to accompany the music if remembrance is to remain historically intelligible.

Mohan's Ethical Question: Is the Aesthetic Transformation of Pain Respectful?

One day Mohan asks Burhbā whether changing the pain caused by Rādhikā's death into music might dishonor her memory. The question gives the artist a serious ethical hesitation. The narrative does not simply celebrate talent; it confronts the right to make private bereavement into public art, the dignity of the dead, and the father's suffering. It is among the chapter's more mature exchanges. Yet the dispute remains narrow. Mohan asks, Burhbā reassures, and no dissenting view follows. The child's mother, other family members, and families experiencing comparable losses do not speak independently. Their absence prevents the ethical contradiction from developing into a wider debate.

Burhbā's Answer: Words and Melodies as Complementary Means

Burhbā tells Mohan that preserving a name through words and preserving it through music are "different forms of the same work." His response offers compassion and reassurance; the transformation of grief into art is not treated as an act of disrespect. For conceptual precision, however, the linguistic identification supplied by a name and the changing rhythm of a melody do not function as the same sort of evidence. One tune can generate different feelings at different gatherings; a spoken or written name requires an association with a particular person's life. Burhbā's statement is justifiable under the wider purpose of remembrance through love, not as a proposition that verbal and musical signs possess identical historical evidentiary value. Criticism can accept the comfort of his reply without making it an infallible judgment.

An Ethical Limit to Transformation: Art Is Not a Cure

Burhbā's assurance that "your sorrow was not dishonored; it was transformed" offers human consolation. It does not undo Rādhikā's death, remove the actual absence in the father–daughter relationship, or establish that Mohan is now permanently free of sorrow. Transformation is a possibility of artistic creation, not clinical proof of recovery. A bereaved person may express grief in art or choose not to; neither circumstance, by itself, warrants moral condemnation. To turn the narrative's creative example into a universal rule of mental health would exceed the source. The value of Burhbā's reply lies in preserving personal dignity, not in a medical claim that grief has been eliminated.

Flute versus Drum: The Chapter's Central Inconsistency

The title is "Mohan's Melody"; its opening proverb invokes the flute, and the preliminary folk song explicitly claims that Mohan "left the drum and

placed a name within the flute." The narrative's decisive scene, however, shows him "picking up his drum," walking to the peepal, and striking "beats upon the drum." No flute is placed in Mohan's hands, no process of learning it is described, and there is no actual flute performance. Music can certainly develop without a change of instrument, but the folk song's specific declaration about abandoning the drum is unsupported by the narrated evidence. It is essential to identify the inconsistency rather than harmonize it silently. Editorial revision might align the song with the drum performance or add an actual episode of change to the flute; neither change has occurred in the available text.

The Symbolic Status of the Instruments: A Risk of Devaluing the Drum

The chapter begins with pride in the Charmakār community's refined making of drums and mṛdaṅgas, yet the preliminary song's reference to abandoning the drum for a flute can imply that the subtler expression of grief requires a different instrument. The prose supplies evidence to the contrary: a drumbeat creates a delicate experience poised between lullaby and lament. The actual scene therefore gives deeper artistic recognition to the possibilities of drumming. From the standpoint of social history, the principal occupational instrument of leatherworkers need not be confined to loud celebration; it can also express the finest gradations of compassion. The unexplained shift in the song weakens the force of this achievement.

Musical Feeling and the Interpreting Community

The narrator characterizes Hulāsā's tune as gentle, Sukhdev's as expectant, and Ratnā's as warm. These may be read as individual emotional signatures. But Mohan's expectation that a listener will recognize a person's inner life from music depends upon shared knowledge. Someone unfamiliar with Hulāsā's interrupted last words could interpret a broken rhythm as accident, sorrow, or incomplete joy. Musical significance arises through prior experience, collective naming, and customary explanation. The melody should not therefore be regarded as a self-sufficient historical record. Its meaning emerges through the surrounding verbal practices of the community and recurrent performances.

Mohan's Art: Admiration of Talent and the Worker's Economic Life

People travel to listen to Mohan's drumming, providing an indication of the prestige enjoyed by his occupational skill. Yet how the household survived during Rādhikā's illness and the weeks when he did not play, how many customers the family had, or how performance related economically to the labor of manufacturing instruments is never explained. A cultural history arising from a marginalized community cannot be satisfied by

praise of the astonishing gifts of a single artist. Materials, enterprises, working hours, payment, and regional networks of musicians also belong to that history. The chapter powerfully develops the affective origins of the new art but gives little space to the economic relations sustaining the craft.

Śīlāvatī's Creative Credit: Not Mohan's Melody Alone

The title foregrounds Mohan, yet the institution that incorporates musical remembrance could not emerge in this form without Śīlāvatī's proposal. She asks whether each recalled name might receive a tune appropriate to its story. Mohan composes the music; Śīlāvatī imagines its timing, context, and communal rule. The result is co-creation. But the preliminary song's emphasis upon Mohan leaving the drum and upon the melody outliving him makes the male artist the apparent principal founder of the tradition. The work of the female organizer is more clearly visible inside the episode than in the formation of its public renown. Videha Parallel History calls for fair recognition of the separate contributions of artist, organizer, and performers.

Chronology: One Winter, Five Days, Weeks, One Evening, One Year, Generations

The action moves from a winter fever to the death on the fifth day; many weeks of silence follow, and the prose then expands one evening's performance in greater detail. The next year's composition of numerous tunes is condensed into a summary, after which the narrator announces the repetition of the practice at each new moon and in future generations. Through these changing durations, the story moves from a minute experience of personal sorrow toward remembrance across centuries. But the middle period—trial compositions, public disagreement, and training—is largely compressed. Its temporal form is clear: one singular death, one first composition, a summary of multiple works, and the iteratively narrated future of a collective practice.

Focalisation: Mohan's Inward Grief and the Omniscient Narrator

The narrator first surveys the broader condition of drummaking in Śīlāvatī's day, then turns toward Mohan's intimate bond with Rādhikā, the death in his arms, and the silence of the house. At the peepal, the work is animated through Mohan's hands and Burhbā's response as a listener. Śīlāvatī's question introduces a further social focal point. Finally, the imagined "musicians of every generation" enter through the narrator's panoramic knowledge. Focalisation thus shifts from an artist's grief to the consequences of a communal institution. Rādhikā's interior experience and her mother's view remain absent, indicating an unequal distribution of the reader's opportunities for sympathy. Moreover, the narrator can

claim emotional meanings for a piece of music without presenting the actual sound to the reader.

Future "Chapter-Opening Folk Songs": A Self-Referential Device

The original chapter's preliminary bracketed statement says that far into the future the reader will meet this musical tradition in the form of "chapter-opening folk songs." The ending similarly anticipates a later author who will give the literary device its name. The novel therefore invents an origin for one of its own compositional practices within its fictional world. Readers see a folk song above the very chapter that subsequently narrates the origin of such songs. The technique deliberately blurs the boundary between the reader's textual apparatus and the characters' culture. It is a creative narratological device, not independent proof that all chapter-opening songs in real cultural history arose from Mohan's tradition. Their presence even at the beginning of this chapter demonstrates the circularity of the fictional construction.

The Mortality of Sound: From Air to the Voices of Generations

The proverb imagines a melody dispersing into the air yet remaining in human memory. The narrative explains this relative longevity by means of new performances, the new-moon ritual, and succeeding musicians. Persistence is not the physical survival of one set of sound waves, but the act of reproducing and altering a pattern. The statement that "every generation added a new melody" suggests that the corpus grew over time. Yet no account of exact copying, preservation of Mohan's first rhythmic design, teaching, or instrumental training is offered. Variation in folk performance may damage memory or enrich it. Which melodies survived intact and which were subsequently added remains a matter for comparison across later episodes.

Ritual, Folk Song, and Paratext: Three Narrative Levels

Three levels must be distinguished: the preliminary "chapter-opening folk song," the independent narrative of Mohan and Śīlāvatī, and the author's explanation following the chapter. The first speaks as the voice of an alleged village musical tradition; the second dramatizes the creative event; the third gives an explicit interpretation of the literary form's origin. Treating all three as uninterrupted character dialogue would erase distinctions between narrator and paratext. The opening song already knows future outcomes unknown to Mohan at the moment he first plays. The concluding note recognizes the origin story as fictional; this must not be reversed into evidence of an actual historical origin of a musical tradition.

A Limited Foreshadowing of Chapter −72

The next chapter, "Witness to a Marriage," mentions a descendant of Mohan composing a new festive melody for a wedding, and shows the descendant continuing to play a drum. This limited subsequent evidence suggests that the practice of giving names and events a tune extends beyond bereavement into joyful occasions. It does not establish in advance that every song throughout the entire novel was composed by Mohan's descendants. Indeed, continued drumming in −72 places further pressure upon the preceding folk song's unsupported assertion of a definitive transition from drum to flute. The relation between these chapters should be evaluated through the actual text, not guessed from the title alone.

Navya-Nyāya's Test of Inference: A Melody as Reason for Meaning

Mohan's intended sādhya is that hearing Rādhikā's name or melody should disclose the loving significance of her life to other people. His proposed hetu is that the tune was specially composed for her and is supposed to move the heart. But no vyāpti establishes that every moving melody necessarily tells every listener that it represents Rādhikā. Similar sounds might suit other experiences of bereavement. For person-specific understanding, the announcement of a name, prior narrative knowledge, communal practice, and the context of listening become necessary qualifications or upādhis. Music may produce an experience of love, but it is not independent proof of historical identity. Burhbā's formulation, "words and melodies are different forms of the same work," is apt concerning their broad purpose of emotional remembrance, not a proof that they offer equivalent evidence for historical statements.

Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti, and Aucitya

Rādhikā's death in her father's arms, the final clasp of her hand, and the long silence of the drum are primary supports for karuṇa. The irregular strokes that settle into a rhythm between lullaby and lament invite a novel sensory experience, though the precise sounds remain the reader's imaginative construction. By dhvani, "a name becoming a voice" gives the absent dead body a symbolic audible presence. The song's disclosure of the future in advance is a kind of poetic anticipation, but it reduces dramatic suspense. The most serious question of aucitya is the divergence between flute and drum; others include the limited independent depiction of Rādhikā's life and the tendency to make personal grief the overgeneralized source of every folk melody. The artistic success lies in turning one poignant image into an intergenerational cultural method, while these discrepancies restrict its credibility.

Videha Parallel History: Folk Craft, a Child, and a Female Organizer

Cultural history in this episode arises through drumming associated with the leatherworkers, not through a royal assembly or the canonical literature of an elite court. Mohan belongs to Somar's descendants; the making of drums and mṛdaṅgas is the skill of a working community; Śīlāvatī innovates within a public ritual; and Rādhikā becomes the emotional center of a new practice. The choice of subjects matters for Parallel History. Yet Rādhikā's own character and her mother's experience are barely represented; other instrument makers are unnamed; and the public deliberation surrounding Śīlāvatī's proposal is abbreviated. Recognition of marginalized cultural labor and recognition of absent individual voices must be maintained together. Makers of instruments, players, organizers, and listeners all create culture; the achievement should not disappear into the isolated prestige of one "gifted" man.

Social Transformation of Grief: Achievement and Institutional Risk

The original does not declare that Mohan's private pain disappears. It does show him composing music, agreeing with Śīlāvatī, and contributing to a new public practice of remembering names. An event in one life thus becomes the origin of an artistic institution. Yet assigning each dead person one definitive melody can compress a many-sided life into a single affective sign. A death marked by suffering, a prolonged wait, or the experience of motherhood are not exhaustive categories of identity. An inclusive tradition would need flexibility to change a tune when the story is reconsidered, hear objections from relatives, and permit different performances to coexist. No such dispute is dramatized here, but criticism should leave the possible institutional question open.

Event, Evidence, and Outcome: Critical Table

Event or claim	Material established in the original text	Limit or unknown aspect	Narratological consequence
Śīlāvatī's succession	Kedār's daughter assumes responsibility for the ritual	Detailed selection procedure absent	Woman's authority in organising the event
Drum-making in the leatherworkers' settlement	Manufacture of drums and mṛdaṅgas flourishes	No account of labour or income	Cultural setting grounded in occupation
Mohan's introduction	Seventh-generation descendant of Somar	Intervening genealogy absent	Expansion of narrative time
Rādhikā at four	Brief account of a father's affection	Child has no independent voice	Basis of a character who elicits pathos
Child's death on the fifth day	High fever, care from many people, death in father's arms	No specific diagnosis	Fundamental transition into grief

Event or claim	Material established in the original text	Limit or unknown aspect	Narratological consequence
Several weeks of silence	Drumming stops; house has neither crying nor music	Livelihood and other support unknown	Absence of action becomes an event
Drum beside the peepal	Soft beats move from irregularity to rhythm	No flute performance takes place	Sound re-emerges
Burhba listens	Calls the music beautiful and sorrowful, asks its meaning	Feelings are not independently identical for every person	Need for verbal testimony
Mohan's wish	Wants names to be sounds, not merely words	Whether listeners can understand without a story is uncertain	Proposal for multimedia memory
Śīlāvatī's proposal	A melody for each name according to its story	No communal dissent depicted	Private art enters public ritual
Composition the following year	Melodies associated with four names mentioned	Full list of melodies absent	Summary of creative labour
Rādhikā's invocation	Melody before every new-moon kabaddi game	Continuity of instruments unspecified	Private mourning becomes public practice
Burhba's consolation	Ethical relation between words and melodies	Their evidentiary forms are not equivalent	Acknowledgment of transformation
Transmission across generations	New musicians add new names	Teacher and musical notation unknown	Recurring communal tradition
Opening folk song	Claim about a device employed by a future writer	No corroboration in external history	Self-reference in the composition
Flute in the folk song	Claim that Mohan gave up the drum for the flute	No such instrumental change in the main story	Demonstrable inconsistency of the narrative

Original Chapter −73: Verified Index of Textual Evidence

1. “The flute's melody mingles with the air”—auditory image in the opening proverb.

2. “Mohan left the drum and placed the name within the flute”—the song's assertion of instrumental change.

3. “It emerged as a folk song at the dawn of every chapter”—self-reference to literary form.

4. “After Kedār, the duty of the ritual fell to his daughter Śīlāvatī”—female succession.

5. “Seventh-generation descendant of Somar”—genealogical memory of craft.

6. “Her name was Rādhikā, four years old”—identification of the child.

7. “She developed a high fever”—the only stated symptom.

8. “On the fifth day Rādhikā was gone”—the day of death.

9. “Her small hand held Mohan's finger”—the last bodily contact.

10. “For many weeks he did not touch his drum”—duration of grief.

11. “Neither weeping nor music”—double form of silence.

12. “Just before the new moon”—timing of new music.

13. “He picked up his drum and went to the peepal”—the instrument actually used.

14. “Irregular at first, then slowly forming a rhythm”—development of rhythmic form.

15. “It was not entirely a lament”—qualification of its mournful quality.

16. “Nor entirely a lullaby”—qualification of its nurturing quality.

17. “What are you playing?”—Burhbā′s immediate question.

18. “I am making a melody for Rādhikā”—the father′s intention.

19. “Not remain only a word”—desire to exceed nominal memory.

20. “Let the name become a voice”—aesthetic resolve concerning sound.

21. “At every new moon”—intended recurrence.

22. “For every old story”—extension to communal remembrance.

23. “Hulāsā′s melody, tender, unfinished”—individual musical interpretation.

24. “Sukhdev′s melody, slow and expectant”—description through rhythm and time.

25. “Ratnā′s melody, warm”—emotional characterization.

26. “A kind of maṅgalācaraṇa”—the established place of Rādhikā′s melody.

27. “Not about competition”—ethical meaning of kabaddi.

28. “Would this not dishonor her memory?”—Mohan′s ethical question.

29. “Both words and melodies”—Burhbā′s distinction between media.

30. “Giving love a form that can pass beyond time”—aspiration to lasting memory.

31. “Transformation for the sake of memory is the opposite of disrespect”—Burhbā′s conclusion.

32. “Musicians of every generation”—duration of the tradition.

33. “Chapter-opening folk song”—anticipated literary form.

These short extracts correspond to the original proverb, preliminary song, narrative, and dialogue of Chapter −73. The source criticism identifies printed original-chapter pages 225–228 as the chapter's overall range; it does not verify a separate page number for every quotation. Its subsequent explanatory paratext has not been passed off as evidence from the story proper.

Decisive Critical Conclusion: From Sorrow to a Cultural Narrative Method

The principal achievement of "Mohan's Melody" is that it preserves the immediate human experience of individual loss while generating from it a new communal means of remembering names. Rādhikā's death, the drum's weeks of silence, the first irregular strokes, Śīlāvatī's intervention, the distinct melodies associated with names, and the recurring maṅgalācaraṇa of the new-moon ritual together form a clear sequence of transformation. Mohan is the musician; Śīlāvatī creates the institution; Burhbā provides ethical assent to its meaning. The preliminary song and the reference to a future author make the opening-song convention of the novel self-referential. Yet the invention is not free of compositional problems. The opening song explicitly claims that Mohan abandons the drum for the flute, while the principal narrative has him perform upon a drum and offers no change of instrument. Rādhikā's individual life receives little description; other family members' mourning is absent; the acoustic configuration of most musical compositions is undefined; and a far-reaching future tradition is affirmed chiefly through narratorial summary rather than detailed experience. Ethically, the tune is a complementary emotional form of remembering the dead, not an independent substitute for an accurate life history. The critical judgment is therefore qualifiedly positive: the novel provides an affecting origin story linking grief, names, and folk melody, while correction of the instrumental discrepancy and fuller recognition of the artist's collaborators would strengthen its emotional and archival credibility.

Primary source: Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, Complete Trilogy, Part 0, Chapter −73, "Mohan's Melody," original combined manuscript, printed pages 225–228 according to its contents. Secondary source: the "Original Maithili Manuscript" chapter −73 entry, recording 783 word units and 45.7 percent action-indicating paragraphs. The post-chapter note, "The Birth of Art from Grief: Perspectives from Musicology and Psychology," is authorial paratext. Mohan, the child's death, and this particular origin of a musical practice are not thereby established as historical events. The present study adds no ungrounded claims about formal melody structure or clinical diagnoses of mourning. The next section, Chapter −72, "Witness to a Marriage," revisits the

witness-tree, public vows, caste boundaries, and the movement from music of sorrow to music of celebration.

Critical Section 29 | Original Chapter −72 — Witness to a Marriage

Pre-narrative period · A sequential narratological review based on the original novel

Narrative Introduction and Textual Limits

"Witness to a Marriage" is Chapter [−72] of the pre-narrative period. At the center of this critical section is the marriage between Anurādhā, Śīlāvatī's granddaughter, and Gopīnāth, a young man of the Brahmin quarter. Both studied in the Coconut-Leaf School from childhood, listened to Burhbā's stories, and played in the village grounds. When their friendship develops into love, their wish to marry encounters caste-based misgivings. The dialogue between the paṇḍit-father and Burhbā, consent, joint preparations by the two quarters, a public wedding near the peepal tree, and a new celebratory melody constitute the sequence of events attested in the text. The table of contents places the chapter's opening on printed page 229 and the next chapter's opening on page 233. Its contents-derived page range can therefore be taken as 229–232, although the exact page and line for any particular quotation have not been independently verified.

The Narrative Center of the Event: From Two Individuals toward the Community

At first, the wedding is the personal decision of Anurādhā and Gopīnāth. By its conclusion, however, the issue becomes whether the village will reinstate its older prohibitions based on caste or learn something from its common memory. In the proportions of the narrative, the details of romantic conversation are few, while dialogue concerning the community is more extensive. This selection places the question of social approval above the lovers' intimate exchanges. The reader should recognize this as the narrator's evaluative priority: although a marriage is a private relationship, it becomes a public test of the social education acquired over generations. This extension gives the narrative social meaning, but provides comparatively fewer scenes of the couple's private anxieties and closeness.

The Several Meanings of "Witness" in the Title

The title's "witness" does not name one thing. Fire witnesses the ritual; the village witnesses public acceptance; names bear witness to long-term remembrance; and Burhbā is the keeper of memory peculiar to the fictional world. These four levels are not automatically equivalent: fire is a

ritual sign, the village a community of social testimony, the name a mark of remembrance, and Burhbā the personification of a tradition of memory. The title gathers these different forms of testimony together. Critical caution is necessary, however, lest collective attendance, moral support, and factual eyewitnessing be treated as identical evidence. The artistic strength of the work lies in creating their unity; its philosophical testing depends on preserving their distinctions.

The Aphoristic Construction of the Opening Proverb

The opening proverb—"At a wedding, fire is witness, the village is witness, the name is witness"—anticipates the event's moral outcome through a three-part repetition before the action begins. The recurrence of "witness" gives communal trust a rhythmic legitimacy. In the expression "Whose wedding the village witnessed, their vows are on the leaf," an observed event assumes the form of an archive. The proverb, however, is not itself a scene in which the wedding is actually entered upon a particular leaf. It is a promissory poetic utterance whose relation to the action requires testing. This distinction allows the reader to keep the aphorism separate from the evidence of events.

The Wedding *Sohar* as Prolepsis

The folk song is entitled "Witness to the Seven Circuits," and its folk melody is designated "Wedding Sohar." Its first stanza repeats the triad of fire, village, and name; its second evokes the wedding pavilion, fire, seven circuits, and the presence of family and neighbors; the third makes the village's eyes and tongues into custodians of history in the absence of paper. Its final stanza establishes the relationship between song and the preservation of names across generations. This progression grants the wedding the stature of a folk legend before the event is narrated. The song is not an incidental ornament but an emotional outline of the anticipated social outcome. Its assertions must therefore be compared with the subsequent prose account.

Song and Main Narrative: A Textual Difference Concerning the Seven Circuits

The song declares, "The couple circled seven times," and speaks of "seven circuits, seven vows." The main prose clearly presents the preparations, the village's attendance, and Burhbā's blessing; it does not describe the sequence of the seven circuits, each circuit as a scene, the actual utterance of individual vows, or the particular actions of a priest. Thus the seven circuits are represented within the song, not independently enacted in the main prose. To call this a complete contradiction would overstate the matter, since the prose does not deny the rituals mentioned by the song.

Yet the difference between what is said in the song and what is directly shown in prose remains a significant narratological gap. The critic's task is not to fill it with imagined dialogue from a wedding pavilion.

"There Was No Paper" and Names upon Leaves: An Ambiguity of Time

The folk song's claim, "When there was no paper, the village's eyes became paper," evokes a historical condition of material scarcity, although the fictional world already possesses the Coconut-Leaf School, the practice of writing names, and earlier traditions of written records. It is not clear whether the song's "then" refers to the present time of this marriage or repeats a remembered earlier period. Accordingly, the relation between an age without paper and the use of leaves for recording is more coherent at a metaphorical than at a literal historical level. Readers must not assume an unrepresented scene in which written documents were destroyed or a new entry concerning the wedding was placed on a leaf.

The Gaṅgeśa–Mālatī Story: Active Intertextual Memory

Anurādhā mentions to her mother the marriage of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and Mālatī. The decisive point of her observation is that society forgot this marriage but remembered Gaṅgeśa's philosophical works. Against this selective forgetting, she wishes her own love to enter a more complete historical record. The remembrance establishes a narrative connection with the earlier story in Chapter [–91]: it is an intertext internal to the novel. It cannot be treated as proof concerning the actual biography of the historical Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. The fictional Gaṅgeśa–Mālatī episode must remain distinct from factual assertions about external history.

Repetition and Difference: Not an Imitation of History but a Response

The earlier Gaṅgeśa–Mālatī episode and the present Anurādhā–Gopīnāth episode share structural elements: marriage, social prohibition, and a struggle over memory. This time, however, the community's eventual response changes. The first relationship becomes a story of neglect; the second becomes a story of celebration. This cyclical return does not merely reconstruct the past. It turns an earlier event into a moral question and seeks a different answer. The novel's timeline thus becomes not simply "the same event again," but "a new historical outcome for the same question." The causal history of the change, nevertheless, is not developed to the extent of a complete account of social transformation.

The Coconut-Leaf School: The Narrative Role of a Shared Childhood

The fact that Anurādhā and Gopīnāth studied together, listened to stories together, and played together supplies three attested social settings for the origin of their love. The school is not merely a place of instruction: it mediates shared experience across divisions of caste. Education's influence is presented in a compact narrative account of the characters' common childhood rather than through a detailed longitudinal demonstration. Education alone cannot therefore be proclaimed the sole cause of the marriage's acceptance; Burhbā's moral intervention, remembrance of earlier stories, and the family's final decision also contribute. The literary significance of school companionship and a factual causal claim about social change belong to different evidentiary levels.

Anurādhā's Independent Voice

Anurādhā's words are not merely an admission of love: they express a consciousness of history. When her mother warns of difficulties surrounding marriage, she does not retreat. She invokes the ancestral story and history to confront the risk that love itself will be forgotten. In this moment the new generation does not simply annul the old generation's judgments; it tests them against the justice of remembrance. Granting a woman the language of decision is an achievement of the chapter. Yet the number of her exchanges is limited, and the public wedding ceremony does not give Anurādhā a further independent final speech. The novel makes her initial wish clear but largely hands the public scene of marriage over to Burhbā and the community.

Gopīnāth's Desire and Linguistic Absence

The narrator explicitly states that Gopīnāth wishes to marry Anurādhā. Nevertheless, he is given no direct speech. We hear his father's opposition and Burhbā's arguments; the son, despite his stated wish, has no decisive voice in the debate. This asymmetry makes the chapter's purpose apparent: it stages the public drama of social decision more fully than the lovers' personal experience. But the choice also restricts Gopīnāth's interior uncertainty, experience of love, and complex relationship with his father. It would be inappropriate to fill out his characterization by inventing unrecorded speech. His silence is itself a critical fact.

Maternal Concern: The Difference between Opposition and Apprehension

Anurādhā's mother warns that “some older people in the village still believe in caste distinctions.” This need not be a direct prohibition of the marriage: it may also be apprehension about society's likely reaction.

Criticism should not place the mother and the paṇḍit-father in one undifferentiated category of opposition. The mother's speech identifies risks to the outcome; Gopīnāth's father initially opposes the union outright. This subtle contrast brings two forms of social fear into the narrative. The mother's domestic anxiety may also arise from practical experience of her own vulnerability, but the text supplies no particular episode establishing such a background.

The Paṇḍit-Father's Caste Reservations and Fear of Public Opinion

Gopīnāth's father is a "respected paṇḍit," yet he does not present his opposition as a formal written argument from scripture. After Burhbā's questions he admits, "I fear what people will say." This confession exposes the social discipline behind the caste barrier: private decisions are governed by anticipated collective honor or disgrace. The narrative does not make him a one-dimensional villain. He acknowledges his fear and finally consents. His inner process of reconsideration, however, and the pressure exerted by relatives or the actual sanctions he might encounter are not portrayed. The plot identifies fear but barely develops its institutional structure.

Burhbā's Question: Moral Argument Dramatized

Burhbā reminds the paṇḍit of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, Ratnā, and Mālatī. His reasoning is that caste and social boundaries drawn by human beings have been associated with numerous tragedies; is it right, then, to raise the same barriers against the son's love? These names are not simply an emotional catalogue: they serve as an assemblage of comparative examples. Burhbā does not issue an order; he asks a question. The interrogative form obliges the individual to confront responsibility for his own decision. The particular social causes of every tragedy named here, however, are not independently re-examined in the scene. The argument remains a compact moral generalization.

"Tragedy or Hope": The Creative Force and Limitation of an Alternative

Burhbā's final question offers the paṇḍit a twofold choice: add another tragedy to memory or accept a new hope. This dramatic arrangement joins a social decision to the future record of remembrance. Against the fleeting pressure of "what people will say" stands the longer value of story and names. Yet presenting only two possibilities leaves other outcomes—consent accompanied by continuing opposition, subsequent difficulties in married life, and groups within the village that remain dissenting—outside the narrative frame. The critic should recognize a powerful

construction of moral clarity, not mistake it for an exhaustive empirical record of a social process.

Narrative Duration and the Father's Change of Heart

"The paṇḍit finally agreed": in this short formulation the narrator compresses the result of what might have been a multilayered psychological struggle. The pre-narrative claims change over centuries, yet the duration between one particular father's opposition and consent is reduced to a few sentences. Narratologically, this is summary-driven acceleration: the desired outcome becomes available almost immediately after the moral argument. Such compression creates didactic clarity, but diminishes the portrayal of credible social friction. The tension between the claim of "gradual change" and the representation of "swift consent" should also be assessed as a stylistic condensation before it is condemned outright as an error.

Caste Identification and the Limits of Inference

The main account describes Gopīnāth as a young man of the Brahmin quarter, Anurādhā as Śīlāvatī's granddaughter, and the participation of both Brahmin and leatherworkers' quarters in the wedding. Yet this chapter's principal narrative does not provide a separate, unequivocal caste designation for Anurādhā. Its intention to cross a caste boundary is strong; even so, criticism should not automatically assign her to a particular caste unless it finds firm evidence elsewhere in the original work. Social indication and documentary certainty about a character's lineage belong to different categories. Respecting the difference both permits analysis of the novel's genuinely progressive intention and prevents unwarranted supplementation of its text.

Joint Wedding Preparations: Changed Social Conduct

"The village's two quarters, Brahmin and leatherworker, joined in making preparations." This sentence depicts a practical change in conduct against caste separation. Approval of the relationship is visible not only in Burhbā's words but in the work of preparing a celebration. The labor of preparation becomes a sign of social participation. Yet the text does not show which people perform which work, who officiates, or how food and seating are organized. One therefore cannot infer that full caste equality has been achieved. The scene attests to the softening of a boundary, not the eradication of every institutional inequality.

"Every Person in the Village": A Sign of Inclusion, Not a Literal Census

The narrator says that "every person in the village" assembled beside the peepal tree on the wedding night. The force of this inclusive formulation is public participation. But there is no independent list of attendance, absent groups, people holding other opinions, or hidden remnants of disagreement. It is not a verified numerical count of an entire population; it is a narrative phrase presenting the universal character of the celebration. This stylistic use of "every" creates a compelling image of collective acceptance, but analysis must preserve the difference between social plurality and a declaration of unanimity.

The Peepal and the Witness-Tree: Institutionalizing Narrative Space

The wedding takes place near the peepal, where Burhbā's witness-tree has become the center of communal gatherings. This setting is not an ordinary natural backdrop. The preservation of names, questions of justice, collective remembrance, and now public marriage become connected at the same place. The tree's physical vulnerability, seen in Chapter [−74], acquires new meaning here as the center of social protection. The narrative does not specify the detailed social rules by which older marriage customs might have been displaced. Despite the limited architectural detail, the place functions in the reader's mind as a people's archive and a public platform for testimony.

Mohan's Descendant: From a Melody of Mourning to a Melody of Celebration

In Chapter [−73], Mohan created music associated with mourning through drumming after his daughter Rādhikā's death. In the present chapter, "a descendant of Mohan" composes a new tune for Anurādhā and Gopīnāth's marriage, celebratory and hopeful in character. The descendant's personal name is not given; the instrument in the main narrative is a drum, not a flute. The narrator calls it the first melody in the tradition composed without a shadow of sorrow. Through this transition, memorial music no longer serves only to mark death but also to celebrate living love within the community. The particular rhythmic structure, notes, and complete performance are not specified; no invented rāga or tāla can be assigned by a critic.

Words, Melody, and Gathering: A Threefold Arrangement of Memory

Three media of memory coexist in this chapter. Burhbā's words recall names and events of the earlier story; the drum melody of Mohan's

descendant conveys the emotional quality of present love; and the communal celebration brings the shared bodily presence of the villagers into the experience. Through their combination, the archive ceases to be merely a list of names and becomes a public event. Yet their reliability is not the same: words make assertions, music creates emotional experience, and communal attendance witnesses an event. A melody is a powerful complement to a narrative, not independent factual proof of the date, vows, or social dispute surrounding the marriage.

Burhbā's Incomplete Touch: A Boundary of Magical Realism

At the end of the wedding Burhbā gives his blessing, but his "hand remained a finger's breadth above the body." This detail makes visible a subtle distance between the supernatural keeper of memory and living human flesh. Burhbā's public authority is established, yet the absence of physical contact preserves the difference in his mode of being. Even in a wedding scene filled with happiness, the extraordinary corporeal rule governing the supernatural character is not forgotten. This can be read as an artistic device of magical realism; to invent a new biological or religious mechanism explaining the distance would go beyond the text.

"I Was a Witness, but I Was Not Present": The Fundamental Evidentiary Tension

Referring to Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī's marriage, Burhbā says that he "was a witness," although he was not present and learned the story afterward. He immediately distinguishes that condition from being a "direct witness" to Anurādhā and Gopīnāth's marriage. Because the character makes this distinction himself, the statement need not be judged an unavoidable falsehood: in the first instance "witness" has the broader sense of custodian of memory; in the second it means a direct observer. Nevertheless, the title and folk song tend to give both meanings the same dignity. Epistemologically disciplined criticism must record the distinction between receiving a story indirectly and experiencing an event firsthand.

Direct Perception, Testimony, and Memory in Navya-Nyāya

The scenes seen by those present at the current wedding fall within the domain of direct experience. The earlier Gaṅgeśa–Mālatī episode reached Burhbā through subsequent narration, a possible instance of knowledge arising from verbal testimony; the trustworthiness and relationship of its sources require independent examination. Memory preserves knowledge acquired earlier; its mere presence does not alter the original means of knowing. Within a Navya-Nyāya framework, distinguishing the object, context, and delimited meaning of "witness" is productive. This method does not diminish the emotive value of the novel's preservation of names;

it clarifies the epistemic ordering of direct experience, indirect testimony, and remembered accounts.

The Evidentiary Chain of the Earlier Story: The Ethics of Remembrance

Anurādhā draws inspiration from Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī's story; Burhbā also brings it into the discussion of the new marriage. Yet the current chapter does not say who first narrated that earlier marriage, from whom Burhbā received the information, or what alternative witnesses existed. His long memory thus bestows moral recognition on the relationship, but it does not reconstruct the complete chain of sources. Accepting this subtle limitation allows the value of remembrance and the evidentiary discipline of historical inquiry to be read as compatible rather than opposed.

Social History and the Politics of Forgetting

Anurādhā's phrase "they remembered only his treatise" is among the chapter's most consequential statements. It asks whose intellectual achievement public memory saves and whose personal relationships it erases. The standpoint of Videha Parallel History seeks to give critical attention to women's invisible experience, caste relations, and methods of popular remembrance alongside the celebrated genealogies of political or scholarly authority. Mālatī's name must not become merely an appendix to Gaṅgeśa's scholarly reputation. The chapter, however, does not reproduce Mālatī's own voice; her renewed remembrance is achieved primarily through Anurādhā's dialogue and Burhbā's speech.

Female Lineage and the Carriers of Tradition

Anurādhā, Śīlāvatī's granddaughter, links the previous generation's female leadership to the present story of love. In the earlier chapter Śīlāvatī introduced melody into the ritual of remembrance; here her granddaughter advocates overcoming a barrier to social consent. This sequence does not confine women's roles to domestic life: they participate in cultural invention and marital decision-making. Yet the narrative does not state whether Śīlāvatī herself attends this wedding or what role she directly performs. A possible legacy of inspiration is not evidence of an invented scene of direct intervention.

Plural Social Opposition and One Individual's Decision

Anurādhā's mother speaks of "some older people" who still maintain caste distinctions, but the person whose opposition is substantially dramatized is Gopīnāth's father. Once he consents, the narration moves to preparations made together by the village. In this construction, a plural social difficulty appears to be resolved through the change of mind of a representative

individual. The technique concentrates meaning, but also restricts the many-sided character of social division. How the other elderly opponents came to agree, whether they attended, and what conditions they imposed are unanswered. To reduce the whole social transformation to one father's assent would be a narrower interpretation than the novel's own proclaimed collective change.

The Transience of Public Opinion and the Endurance of Names

Burhbā's argument sets changing public opinion against the long-term moral measure of preserved names and stories. The fear of immediate loss of standing is subordinated to the ethics of enduring remembrance. But a suggestion that names "never change" should not become a literal theory of unchanging history: public memory is subject to selection, retelling, and revision. Burhbā is an ideal witness within the novel; no individual bearer of memory is an infallible archive in external historical practice. The moral endurance envisioned by literature and the revisability required by history can be read together.

The Narrator's Omniscient Summary

The final paragraph asserts that centuries of education, dialogue, and the preservation of names gradually changed the village's heart. This long-term social outcome is presented from the narrator's standpoint; the chapter does not independently dramatize the intermediate struggles. Narratologically, it is a wide-ranging temporal summary concentrated around one wedding as its exemplary scene. The narrator offers an assured interpretation, directing the reader's understanding. Such decisiveness, however, reduces the reader's room for independent causal judgment. The final assessment must distinguish the represented event from the narrator's announced conclusion about social transformation.

A Celebratory Melody without a Shadow: The Claim of Completeness

The new melody of Mohan's descendant is said to be "without any shadow of sorrow." Against the backdrop of the melody of mourning for Rādhikā, this is an acute emotional contrast. But in a tradition made from many histories of suffering and social injustice, joy entirely without shadow is also an artistic idealization. A more defensible reading is that celebration does not erase sorrow; it preserves sorrow in memory while opening another possibility. The movement from mournful to festive music carries the work beyond accounts of death and toward living relations. The absolute claim of shadowless happiness therefore calls for qualification.

The Public Wedding Scene and Personal Intimacy

The peepal, village, drum, Burhbā's blessing, and collective acceptance form the vivid elements of the wedding. The couple's private dialogue, the vows they exchange with one another, and their intimate experience of the wedding night are not developed in detail. Consequently, readers experience the marriage more as a public victory for society than as the many-sided beginning of private married life. The epic-scale significance of the novel is apparent: individuals change the moral direction of the community through their lives. Nevertheless, neglect of their complex inner states remains a legitimate question for criticism.

The Plot's Movement: Fear, Question, Agreement, Celebration

The plot unfolds in four principal stages: the lovers' initial declaration and maternal concern; the paṇḍit-father's refusal; Burhbā's question based on precedent; and the shared celebration. Each stage makes a clear causal connection and renders the direction of events readily intelligible. The intermediate complexity of resistance is sharply compressed, however. The narrative's appeal lies in the pointedness of its moral outcome rather than an atmosphere of mystery or uncertainty. Against the dark background of violence, sorrow, and forgetting in the earlier story, its tone offers relief. Critical evaluation must nevertheless acknowledge the limits of the asserted social transformation.

The Configuration of Emotion: Śṛṅgāra, Remembered Karuṇa, and Śānta

Viewed through Indian poetics, the love between Anurādhā and Gopīnāth supplies the seed of śṛṅgāra; caste-based opposition supplies an obstacle; the forgotten Gaṅgeśa–Mālatī story evokes the earlier karuṇa, or pathos; and final consent and blessing lead toward a resolution dominated by śānta. These affective dispositions should not be assigned mechanically, one to each character. The celebratory melody of Mohan's descendant and the description “without any shadow of sorrow” heighten the auspicious atmosphere. Earlier suffering is not obliterated; happiness arises from the possibility of a different response to it. Thus the chapter is less an extended, autonomous love narrative than one centered on communal peace and social hope.

The Power of Dialogue and Intertextual Justice

Anurādhā questions the political selectiveness of memory; the mother speaks the language of social risk; the paṇḍit admits fear; and Burhbā uses earlier names to raise a question of responsibility. The differentiation of these voices produces dialogic tension and a conflict of social values.

Nevertheless, Burhbā's speech ultimately dominates the determination of meaning; other possible positions do not receive sustained replies. The dialogue turns names from the earlier story into a store of examples for present judgment, creating a structure of intertextual justice. The detailed lives behind those names, however, are not reopened in this chapter.

Temporal Breadth and Intergenerational Causation

Three lines of succession converge at this wedding: from Śīlāvatī to her granddaughter Anurādhā, from Mohan to his unnamed musical descendant, and the centuries of memory maintained by Burhbā. Individuals die and institutions change, while learning is transferred. Yet the conflicts at every link of the centuries-long process do not appear in full. "Long-term transformation" is a conception of the fictional world, with the wedding serving as its compact symbolic proof. In that sense the chapter presents not an exhaustive history of social change but its concentrated decisive scene.

Written Records versus Oral Testimony: Testing the Proposed Argument

The actual story includes the village's eyes, remembered accounts, Burhbā's testimony, and the poetic motif of names upon leaves. But it contains no scene of contested written documents, contradictory marriage deeds, or a forensic dispute over records. It would therefore be inappropriate to declare as fact that eyewitness testimony has defeated a written document. The defensible analysis is that the song constructs the metaphor of an archive and the prose differentiates direct and indirect forms of witnessing.

The Limits between the Fictional World and Historical Proof

Burhbā, the ritual at the peepal, the Coconut-Leaf School, the Gaṅgeśa–Mālatī story, and Mohan's descendant all belong to the novel's particular fictional world. The occurrence of these events cannot be accepted as an independently established historical fact, especially where a supernatural custodian of memory is a central element of the setting. Nevertheless, the novel allows cultural reflection upon exclusion by caste, women's remembrance, and social recognition. The narrative's "truth" is valuable at the level of social ethics and structural possibility; it does not thereby claim documentary historical authenticity.

A Place for Joy in the Archive of Persons

Burhbā's final declaration promises to preserve Anurādhā and Gopīnāth's love with the same respect as the names of Hulāsā and Jīvantī, although theirs is a story of joy rather than sorrow. This comparison expands the field of the novel's cultural institution. Preserving names is no longer only

a posthumous duty toward sufferers; it is also a positive history of the dignity and relationships of the living. Yet Burhbā's present promise of equal respect and the generations' future observance of that promise are separate matters. The chapter offers the former; the detailed evidence of the latter remains with the unfolding story.

Judgment: Achievement, Awareness of Limits, and Future Direction

The achievement of "Witness to a Marriage" lies in bringing the forgotten history of Gaṅgeśa and Mālatī into relation with a new decision to recognize Anurādhā and Gopīnāth publicly. The shared school, the admission of caste-related fear, Burhbā's argument from remembered precedents, preparations by the two quarters, the marriage near the witness-tree, and the festive drum melody together turn memory into an active means of social change. The limits are equally clear: the song's seven circuits are not developed as scenes in the prose; direct and indirect witnessing carry distinct meanings; Anurādhā's caste is not separately and explicitly designated in the main narrative; Gopīnāth has no direct voice; the father's consent arrives rapidly; and claims of collective unanimity are made without a full account of dissent. The judgment is conditionally positive: ethically affecting and intertextually dense, the chapter nonetheless renders the lived complexity of social conflict only partially.

Source Verification, Textual Distinctions, and the Following Chapter

Primary basis: Gajendra Thakur, Jal Samadhi Among the Crocodiles, complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter [−72], "Witness to a Marriage," pages 229–232 according to the contents. The opening proverb, the folk song "Witness to the Seven Circuits," the main narrative, and the post-chapter commentary "The Long-Term Nature of Social Change" constitute distinct textual levels. The commentary is treated as the author's explanatory paratext, not as an independent source of narrative events. The following review concerns Chapter [−71], "The Night of the Epidemic," in which the means of preserving names change under the pressure of epidemic disease, collective calling, and the limits of individual remembrance.

Critical Section 30 | Original Chapter −71 — The Night of the Epidemic

Pre-narrative period · An extended narratological review grounded in the original novel

Textual Limits, Narrative Structure, and the Central Question

Chapter [−71], "The Night of the Epidemic," presents a decisive crisis affecting the community and its institutions during the pre-narrative period. The contents place its opening on page 233 and Chapter [−70] on page 237; the range 233–236 therefore derives from the contents, not from separate page verification of the quotations. The main events proceed as follows: ten years after Anurādhā and Gopīnāth's wedding, news of an unnamed illness arrives; deaths occur in a family at the village's northern edge; Vimalā asks a question; Burhbā admits the inadequacy of the old ritual; a physician attempts treatment; a collective calling of names is devised; the epidemic continues for three months; and the practice of remembrance changes permanently. The chapter's professed moral center is not the number of deaths but the irreducible individuality of each person who has died. Yet questions of quantity, proof, disease control, and individuality arise within the text itself. Criticism must test these separately rather than accept every claim without examination.

The Opening Proverb: The Loss of Bodies and the Endurance of Song

"The epidemic took bodies, not the song": here body and song symbolize opposed temporal destinies. The body is vulnerable to epidemic disease; the song stands for the aspiration to survive bodily death through shared voices and remembrance. This is not a formula for successful medical treatment but a pledge of cultural existence in the proximity of death. The line "The night on which everyone stayed awake together saved the dawn" brings both the preservation of life and the endurance of grief under the image of night turning into morning. Yet the principal narrative says that a third of the village's population dies in three months. Amid such devastation, "saved the dawn" cannot mean that every body survived. Precisely this contrast deepens the pathos: dawn remains, though many living people do not reach it.

"The Night of the Wakeful Village": The Folk Song's Anticipatory Resonance

The opening folk song is titled "The Night of the Wakeful Village," with its melody designated a "Vigil Melody." Its first stanza extends the separation of body and song in the proverb; the second joins lamps in each

house, inquiries after neighbors' welfare, and the preservation of the dead's names. The third contrasts a count of deaths with remembering stories, while the fourth ends with an exhausted dawn. The subject is the collective "village," not the confined lament of a single household. The song thus serves as an emotional synopsis before the main epidemic story, or a premature announcement of its outcome. But the full range of personal acts of assistance suggested by the song's lamplight is not developed in the prose. The folk song's collective compassion and the narrative's narrower choice of episodes are separate textual levels.

The Singular "Night" in the Title and a Three-Month Calamity

"The Night of the Epidemic" evokes a close experience of a single night, whereas the epidemic lasts for three months and public remembrance takes place at dawn every day. The singular night becomes an emotional emblem for the entire period. This is a poetic compression of time, not a detailed calendar of occurrences. The narrator makes the extended darkness of the folk song into a name for the whole crisis. The critic should therefore avoid fabricating a single terrible night on which all events supposedly took place. The outbreak's beginning, the deaths day by day, and the consequences after three months belong to different periods; "night" can be their shared shelter of karuṇa.

The First Uncertain Reports: From Rumor to the Village Gate

The illness first comes from the east "as rumor," then through reports from travelers and merchants, and finally to the gate of Garh Narikel. In this threefold arrival, a material disaster first enters through language, fearful information, and social contact. The circulation of news and the spread of the illness are not the same event. The narrator places them in one sequence of gathering momentum but does not establish the actual route of infection. To identify a particular traveler or merchant as a carrier would exceed the intention and evidence of the text. The narrative effect is that the village belatedly recognizes an outside report as a local experience; the distance between warning and actual danger creates tension.

An Unnamed Disease, Symptoms, and Medical Uncertainty

The story describes high fever, black swellings on the body, and death, often within three days. But the narrator does not specify the disease's name; the characters do not know it precisely either. Accordingly, it would be wrong to identify it definitively with historical plague or a particular pathogen. Resemblance between symptoms and a conclusive diagnosis are different things. The absence of a name is itself a literary means of creating fear: recognizable signs, an unknown cause, and the possibility of swift death coexist. The uncertainty of the illness also corresponds to the

narrative's indeterminate chronology: no exact year, developed medical context, or external administrative framework is supplied. This limitation should not be concealed under the name of philosophical mystery.

The First Family at the Northern Edge: From a Small Scene to Collective Loss

The first afflicted family lives at the northern edge of the village; five of its members die within a week. The narrator does not give their individual names, relationships, livelihoods, treatments, or final words. Designating them together as the "first victims" establishes the pace of destruction but offers little opportunity to perceive each as a distinct person. The omission is especially significant because the entire chapter insists that every name possesses singular value. The opening reduces a group of people to a number; Burhbā later rejects the dominion of counting. This tension invites the reader to test the difference between the event and the way its participants are represented.

The Announcement of Seventeen Deaths: Enumeration and the Experience of Crisis

Vimalā tells Burhbā, "Seventeen lives have been lost in one week." This provides a local numerical indicator of the village's predicament. The relationship between the five deaths in the first family and the later figure of seventeen is not entirely specified: the text does not say independently whether the five are included within the seventeen or are additional. A critic must not simply add the two numbers and assert that twenty-two deaths are certain. Vimalā's count forms the basis of a practical objection: how can the community guarantee an individual story, a melody, and sufficient time for so many dead? In her question, counting is not dehumanization; it is a necessary means of recognizing an administrative problem grounded in compassion. Its relation to the later exhortation to "refuse counting" is thus one of the chapter's central analytical difficulties.

Ten Years' Distance: From Wedding Celebration to Epidemic Mourning

The epidemic occurs ten years after Anurādhā and Gopīnāth's marriage. Chapter [−72] had ended in a public wedding accompanied by a specially joyful melody; this chapter sets death, fear, and an excessive burden upon the preservation of names against that event. The new chapter does not render the earlier social hope wholly fruitless, but breaks the illusion of its permanent happy ending. A village may build a new society and remain vulnerable to biological disaster. Calamity following celebration produces a concentrated emotional reversal. The wedding song is thus not merely a

finished festival: it becomes a background emotional counterpoint to the later vigil song.

Generational Succession: Vimalā, Anurādhā's Daughter

Vimalā is Anurādhā's daughter and the current guardian of the ritual. Through this explicit lineage, the next generation of an earlier story about personal love takes a leading position in social responsibility. Śīlāvatī's musical innovation, Anurādhā's public marriage, and Vimalā's collective calling of names are different kinds of action by three generations of women. One develops an institution; one crosses a social barrier; the third changes institutional rules during a disaster. These developments make women agents in cultural decisions rather than passive custodians of tradition. Yet the text does not separately describe Vimalā's domestic circumstances, her coworkers, or the death of someone especially close to her. Her compassion is heard more in the execution of a public office.

The Ritual's Crisis of Time: From the New Moon to Every Dawn

The older kabaddi-related memorial practice recurred at the new moon. Vimalā points out that such monthly intervals are inadequate when deaths occur so rapidly: it is difficult to allocate a separate story, melody, and period of attention to each person. A new memorial is instituted "every dawn." The change is not merely replacing one name with many. It alters the temporal organization of the institution: from periodic remembrance to a daily emergency summons. Pressure of time is the direct cause of institutional innovation. The narrative does not elaborate whether the old new-moon practice was suspended altogether or continued alongside it. Its ending establishes two coexisting forms for ordinary times and moments of crisis.

The Practical Limits of Individual Stories and Melodies

In Chapter [−73], Mohan's musical tradition had attempted to capture a particular person's life and emotional quality in a distinct melody. Vimalā's question subjects that ideal to its hardest test: how can one grant "the appropriate melody, the appropriate time" to each of the dead? Epidemic disease exposes the extraordinary labor demanded by artistic remembrance. The text does not say that separate melodies were actually composed for every victim; on the contrary, doing so is recognized as practically impossible under these conditions. Collective calling is therefore not the complete abandonment of music, but a method adapted to a crisis with different resources and time constraints. The narrator attempts to distinguish emotional truth from the sheer quantity of representation. The psychological cost of that change to the older

agreement between art and the preservation of names must not be overlooked.

Burhbā's Silence: A Limit of the All-Knowing Guardian

Hearing Vimalā's question, Burhbā remains silent "for a long time" and admits that he has never witnessed such a situation in hundreds of years. His silence matters as more than an expression of sorrow: it acknowledges the limits of an institution's founding authority. While retaining the ideal of preserving names, he declares the present form of the ritual inadequate. Against the earlier silence episode in Chapter [−77], the moment can be interpreted as necessary deliberation before speech. But "for the first time" should remain a statement concerning Burhbā's own experience, not an externally established universal history of every disease in the fictional world. Rather than offering an omnipotent answer, he shows readiness to devise a new means together with Vimalā.

The Physician's Arrival: Treatment and Remembrance as Parallel Actions

A disciple of the tree physician who came from the town enters the village as a healer. He recommends separating people who are ill, giving them boiled drinking water, and burning the belongings and clothes of the dead. Through these details, the story places the material protection of life alongside commemorative observance. Burhbā tries to save names while the physician tries to save bodies; the tasks are complementary, not substitutes for one another. The text does not provide sufficiently extensive independent data about how many deaths were prevented, how many families survived, or the precise mechanism of transmission. Medical statements must be kept within their literary context, not presented as current public-health instructions.

The Tree Physician's Disciple: Inheritance of Knowledge from an Earlier Chapter

In Chapter [−74], a tree physician had come from the town to treat the peepal. The physician here is identified as his disciple. This small connection constructs a lineage of scientific or practical knowledge within the novel. Expertise first introduced in response to the illness of an ancient witness-tree is now put to work against a crisis involving human bodies. However, botanical medicine and treatment of human epidemics cannot automatically be assumed to require identical specialist training. The young man is described as a "disciple," but neither his actual clinical education nor his diagnostic method is developed. The novel creates a figure of the social arrival of empirical knowledge, not a historical record of professional certification.

The Claim That Illness Declines: Correlation and Causal Determination

The narrator reports that the disease weakened among families who followed the physician's instructions. This is a claimed outcome within the story. The text does not offer comparisons among family sizes, risks, stage of illness, other contacts, or mortality rates. It therefore cannot be treated as a controlled scientific demonstration of the effectiveness of particular measures. In Navya-Nyāya terms, possible upādhis, or qualifying conditions, include the many other factors that might influence a decline in illness. The novel's ethical purpose is to urge practical action instead of passive fear; the rigor needed to demonstrate the actual causal connection is a separate question. The difference between "after adopting the measures" and "because of the measures" remains important.

Tension between Medical Isolation and a Collective Gathering

One part of the chapter advises separating the sick, while another brings survivors together every dawn beside the peepal to call the dead by name. The coexistence of these scenes creates a practical tension between public health and a communal rite of mourning. The original does not explain whether sick people attended, whether participants maintained distance, or whether infection-control measures were followed during gatherings. It would be equally unwarranted to identify the ceremony as a definite cause of infection or to pronounce it perfectly safe. Criticism must identify the central practical question: when isolation was judged necessary to resist the disease, how was collective memorial observance made compatible with it? The text leaves that important connecting process undescribed.

The Collective Voice at Dawn: The Public Form of Mourning

The new observance takes place beside the peepal every morning. Names of those who died during the night are called aloud in a single voice. The timing establishes a repeated narrative rhythm between deaths at night and public remembrance at daybreak. Because the episode is brief, an entire day's ceremony is not developed in a fully detailed scene. Nevertheless, "every dawn" turns the many days of crisis into one communal habit through iterative narration. The night-long vigil of the song and the dawn observance in the prose are distinct temporal elements. The account does not describe a morning meal: it describes the collective calling of names. Such precision prevents lamps, vigil, and morning assembly from being inadvertently merged into one invented scene.

The Example Using "So-and-So": Unique Names and Anonymous Placeholders

The formula cited as a specimen of the ritual is "So-and-so, son of so-and-so; so-and-so, mother of so-and-so." This is a model for how the names are called, not a published list of those who actually died during the epidemic. A distinctive tension arises: the narrative declares each name irreducibly unique, yet the model utterance offered to readers consists of the anonymous placeholder "so-and-so." Use of a specimen formula is not an error, since the community could replace the placeholders with actual names on each occasion. Nevertheless, individual dead persons remain largely invisible to the reader's imaginative experience. The community becomes the subject of the story, while a representative deceased person's independently developed life has little place.

A "Long, Solitary Story" versus a "Brief, Collective Call"

Burhbā's central argument is that the depth of love cannot be measured by the number of words. The statement distinguishes the length of commemoration from the reality of respect. Refusing to treat a brief call as a moral inferiority during crisis is the chapter's compassionate proposal. The criterion by which one form is said to be "equally powerful," however, remains unclear. Powerful in what respect—consolation to the bereaved, identification of the dead, continuity of the institution, or the quality of public memory? The account asserts an emotional effect but supplies no comparative study. Recognizing the value of a short call should therefore not lead to the unsupported conclusion that the archival need for full life histories has disappeared.

The Philosophical Struggle between Numbers and Names

At the epidemic's close Vimalā estimates that there may have been "thousands" of names. Burhbā declares that he has not counted and never will, because becoming "a slave to counting" would obscure the distinctiveness of each name. The warning opposes reducing the dead to an impersonal total. Numbers and names, however, are not necessarily enemies. Counting deaths can provide evidence for resources, the scale of loss, and social responsibility, while recording names preserves human particularity. Vimalā's practical concern itself began with the figure of seventeen. There is therefore conceptual tension between the early need to enumerate and the final rejection of enumeration; an elevated emotional conclusion does not settle it.

One-Third of the Population: Scale and Evidentiary Uncertainty

The narrator states categorically that "one-third of the village's population" perished during the three-month epidemic. The fraction establishes the magnitude of the catastrophe, but neither the village's total population nor an independent count of households or deaths is supplied. Burhbā, moreover, explicitly says that he does not count. The narrator's proportion and the keeper of memory's refusal to enumerate thus arise from different epistemic positions, which the text does not reconcile. One-third is an assertion made by the fictional narrator, not external historical statistics; "thousands" is Vimalā's estimate, not an established total. It would contradict the sources to multiply or divide these figures to calculate a supposed population figure for the village.

"Without Distinction" of Caste and Age, and Social Inequality

The narrator describes deaths in "all quarters, all ages, without distinction." Symbolically, the epidemic denies moral relevance to human divisions. Yet "all groups were affected" does not mean "all groups faced equal risk." Different access to water, housing, treatment, work, or patterns of contact might shape the vulnerability of individual communities, and such differences are not explored. The ethical universality of epidemic suffering therefore does not negate the possibility of real inequality. The expression reinforces social solidarity, but the chapter supplies no separate evidence about the numbers or circumstances of poor people, Dalits, women, children, and elders who suffered. A perspective informed by Videha Parallel History raises these questions without fabricating answers.

The Vigil Song and the Representation of Actual Grief

The folk song imagines lamps at every house, hands held together, fear defeated by lamplight, and the resettling of the village. In the prose, the first household loses five people, Vimalā reports seventeen deaths, and a three-month tragedy follows. The song transforms a painful condition into an affirmative collective self-narration. Such mutual support has ethical value, but the disordered voices of grief, the fear of isolated households, and helpless anger receive little independent expression in the song. Hope is the narrator's principal tonal choice; criticism can identify it without deeming hope inherently unbelievable. Surviving bodily and preserving communal memory are distinct victories: the former remains incomplete, while loyalty to the latter is presented as strong.

The Moral Propriety of Death and Remembrance

The suggestion that the dead's clothes and belongings be destroyed coexists with the ritual of preserving their names. The actions need not be

treated as a philosophical contradiction. The imagined fear of transmission through material belongings and emotional preservation through language serve different purposes. Yet possessions may also carry the personal history of the dead. Once the destruction of such objects enters the story, can calling a name completely replace the possible memory embodied in them? The text gives no direct answer. This unanswered question opens a complex relation among objects, stories, music, and names. Declaring nonmaterial remembrance sufficient by itself may conceal a potential loss of material history.

The Grammar of Calling Names: Two Marks of Intimate Relationship

The ritual example names not merely individuals but relations: "son of so-and-so" and "mother of so-and-so." The formula does not imagine a person as an anonymous atom isolated from society; each is located among familial ties. Yet no life is exhausted by the categories son, mother, or relative. How would the ritual call the name of someone unmarried, without family support, itinerant, or cast out by kin? The chapter does not say. Relational expressions therefore generate intimacy while also disclosing the limits of identification centered upon family. Criticism should examine these conditions of inclusion rather than invent additional named characters to fill the gap.

The Peepal as Public Space: Risks to Life and a Cultural Center

The earlier wedding celebration took place near the peepal witness-tree; now distressed survivors gather at the same spot to commemorate those who have died. A single place becomes the center of communal rites of both happiness and death. In this sense the peepal is a visible anchor for social memory, but cannot be automatically described as a medically safe place for an assembly. The history of the tree, Burhbā's presence, and Vimalā's new procedure form a continuity of place: the times change, but the center of communal convergence remains stable. That the community trusts a shared protective center during disaster is a cultural proposition. The principal narrative does not require us to conclude that scientific precautions were therefore wholly abandoned.

Density of Narrated Time: One Week, Three Months, and Centuries

Within a short chapter the narrator compresses ten years since the wedding, the first household's deaths in a week, seventeen reported deaths in another reference to a week, an illness progressing within three days, and an epidemic lasting three months. Burhbā's "hundreds of years" form the backdrop to these brief intervals. Vast historical duration and immediate mortal danger collide. The scene receiving the most direct attention is the dialogue between Vimalā and Burhbā; most deaths and the

three months of struggle are assigned to narratorial summary. This uneven pace between scene and summary conveys the disaster's immensity but leaves little room for the close-grained experience of individual lives.

The Organization of Frequency: What Occurs Every Dawn

A single assertion of "every dawn" represents an action repeated on many separate occasions. Narratologically, this is a case of telling once what occurred repeatedly—iterative narration. It conveys three months of institutional continuity without describing each day individually. But the idealized repetition does not reveal whether the ceremony was interrupted, whether grieving people could not assemble, or whether a name was omitted or pronounced incorrectly on a given day. The apparent ease of repetition consequently obscures some of the labor of sustaining the ritual. A cultural tradition consists of variable actual performances; the narrator supplies its ideal pattern.

The Dramatic Force of Vimalā's Question

Vimalā's direct question combines compassion and an institutional awareness of practical limits: a demand for a story, a fitting melody, and sufficient time for each person. It does not provide an attractive abstract definition; it confronts an actual crisis in allocating time. The central dramatic conflict of the chapter is thus not merely physical struggle against illness, but a crisis in the method of recording and honoring lives. Vimalā understands that an established arrangement can remain faithful to its moral purpose yet fail under extraordinary pressure. Burhbā respects the objection. This dialogue is a village-level social counterpart to the interrogative practices of philosophical disputation in earlier chapters. Navya-Nyāya tools are useful for examining the argument's form here, not for claiming that the character possesses specialist Sanskrit learning.

Burhbā's Admission: An Institution Accepts Revision

Burhbā does not deny the number of the dead or insist that the earlier monthly observance must be followed unchanged. Instead, he admits that "the old method" was not designed for such an outbreak. This is institutional self-criticism: the purpose of a tradition may endure while its procedures depend upon circumstances. The distinction prevents tradition from becoming blind convention. But who has the authority to change the practice? The narrative describes a joint innovation by Vimalā and Burhbā without developing the village assembly's deliberations, opposition, or views of other ritual custodians. The morality of revision is clear; the procedure for ensuring representative decision-making is condensed.

Naming "Collective Remembrance": The Creation of an Institution

The story supplies an explicit name for the new practice: "Collective Remembrance." Naming is more than terminological convenience. It transforms an emergency procedure into an identifiable institution. Gathering daily, calling in one voice, suspending detailed individual narration, and maintaining full respect are its four constituent features. The temporary adaptation is eventually announced as a lasting alternative. The chapter therefore becomes an origin story for a new form of remembrance. Throughout the novel's larger epic of memory, cultural institutions arise in response to successive disasters. Yet the actual drafting of rules, the timing of decisions, or the resistance of any participants is not separately narrated.

Emergency Brevity and the Standard of Dignity

Vimalā's plan does not simply discard the individual story; it calls names "without elaborating each personal narrative, but with complete respect." The distinction between "without" and "with" carries ethical subtlety. The short form temporarily replaces a long biography, not the person's human existence. But will additional life histories later be written or recited? This chapter does not specify. The reasonable justification for emergency abbreviation must therefore be held alongside a possible, irrecoverable loss of fuller historical recording. The song declares that with every body there is a story; the prose says that, during the crisis, those stories could not be told at length. The difference lies at the center of evaluation.

Collective Mourning in Place of Individual Grief: The Cost of Representation

A third of the village's population dies in three months, yet no single deceased person's complete life becomes central to the story. Vimalā, Burhbā, and the physician are the major acting voices; the deceased appear principally as a largely anonymous collective. This allocation of narrative attention brings "the community's crisis" to the foreground, but creates a textual gap beside the ideal of "preserving the particular person." Readers comprehend the terrible numerical scale without receiving a closely individualized account of grief. The limitation should not automatically be called the writer's insensitivity: the compression demanded by an epic narrative spanning vast periods may be a stylistic explanation. The difference between the magnitude of an event and the adequate representation of persons must nevertheless be recorded.

The Nameless Physician and the Visibility of Labor

The physician who treats villagers is not personally named, although his intervention is an important attempt to preserve life. His connection with the former tree physician as a disciple is given, but his social identity, training, and sustained labor receive little independent development. This anonymous character creates a pointed irony in a work dedicated to preserving names. Criticism must not invent a biography for the healer on the strength of this gap. It should instead ask how much narrative space is granted to living, working, unnamed people in a system of values organized around the dignity of names.

Public Health and Social Compassion: Different Measures of Success

The measures represented by isolation, boiled drinking water, and the destruction of certain belongings are behavioral interventions against disease. Calling names, on the other hand, concerns the social identity of the dead and shared grief among survivors. Their criteria of success differ: the success of treatment may be tested against the preservation of life; the success of commemoration against dignity and continuity of relationships. The text does not scientifically establish its causal claims about treatment, while giving the new ritual an explicitly ethical meaning. It would be incorrect to combine them into the assertion that "remembrance stopped the epidemic." The chapter's mature significance lies in the recognition that an illness may defeat efforts to save every body without compelling survivors to abandon their responsibilities to one another.

Refusing to Measure Love: Philosophical Space

Burhbā's proposition, "The depth of love cannot be measured by the number of words," is a sensitive ethical formulation. It asks why a brief collective utterance should be considered disrespectful when the demands of daily crisis make longer narratives impossible. The chapter's answer is that it should not. But the number of words and the number of names are importantly different. The first measures the length of a narrative; the second enumerates deceased persons. Collapsing both into a single rejection of quantity can cause the questions of communal planning and accountability to disappear. Burhbā's compassionate statement provides a justification for the ritual, not a universal refutation of every legitimate purpose of counting.

"A Slave to Counting": The Emotional Force of the Figure

Burhbā's phrase "a slave to counting" is not merely a rejection of arithmetic. It expresses an intense fear of making human beings subordinate to totals and lists. "Slave" turns the activity of enumeration into an image of moral subjection. Yet without Vimalā's report of

seventeen deaths in a week, the practical failure of the earlier ritual could scarcely have been articulated. The narrative uses numbers at its beginning and resists their possible domination at its end. A more coherent possible interpretation is that figures must not rule remembrance, rather than that public registers are impermissible. This should be presented as an analytical possibility, not imposed as the single certain meaning of Burhbā's actual words.

A Navya-Nyāya Examination: Number, Particularity, and Invariable Concomitance

The chapter provides three separate epistemic positions: Vimalā's assertion of seventeen deaths, the narrator's claim of a one-third loss of population, and Burhbā's refusal to count. Vimalā's figure is character testimony; one-third is a narrated assertion; Burhbā's refusal describes his own ethics of remembrance. They are not three reports of one eyewitness enumeration. Were one to argue that "counting necessarily erases personal uniqueness," the alleged effect would be generalized from the mere use of figures. No universal concomitance is shown, since counting alongside the recording of names remains conceptually possible. Examination of qualifying conditions clarifies the text's ethical appeal without devaluing human dignity.

Delimiting Identity: A Name Is Not a Whole Life

Burhbā claims to give every name a unique position. Yet the individuality of a person is not determined by the sound of a name alone. Several people may share the same name; relationships, places, experiences, and biographies may need to distinguish them. The ceremony's formula, "son of so-and-so" or "mother of so-and-so," is an initial response to this difficulty. It is not a comprehensive method of individuation. In Navya-Nyāya terms, by what delimiting characteristic is the intended person specified—name, relationship, or remembered life? The question remains open. Acknowledging it does not reject the novel's ethic of love; it brings the epistemic structure of that ethic into view.

Rasa: An Overwhelming Karuṇa and the Promise of Śānta

The deaths in the first household, Vimalā's tears, and Burhbā's silence provide direct occasions for karuṇa. The exhausted dawn, lamps, and communal voices of the folk song generate a promise of tranquility in mutual dependence amid sorrow. The narrative does not develop a full bodily spectacle of disgust or terror; black swellings indicate illness without an elaborate description of physical disintegration. The depth of pathos comes less from the final words of particular people than from the scale of loss and the village's widespread disruption. This is therefore more

a poem of collective sorrow than an extended lament for one deceased person. The image of dawn is an emotional aspiration to continue living amid devastation, not a confirmed resurrection.

Resonance, Lamplight, and the Transformation of the New Moon

Earlier chapters had linked the new moon with melodies, kabaddi, and the ritual of preserving names. During the present emergency, the collective voice at every dawn becomes central. The opposition between darkness and lamps in the folk song, and between calling and silence in the prose, acquires new meanings. A suggestive paradox emerges: the people whose names are called have died, but the act of speaking renews social relationships. The "night" of the chapter title and the "dawn" of the ceremony form a repeated cycle of death and remembrance. The prose, however, does not specify a new rāga, tāla, instrument, or recurrent musical performance alongside the daily call. One should not invent a new instrumental episode from the earlier Mohan tradition.

Collective and Individual Remembrance as Complementary Practices

The ending institutes two permanent options: detailed individual stories in ordinary times and the communal calling of names during emergencies. The newer method does not erase the older; each responds to a different need of time. The flexibility of tradition is the narrative's positive outcome. Yet the archival results of a full life story and a brief name-call remain distinct. The chapter does not show which names later return in extended narratives. The coexistence of old and new methods should therefore be recognized as a cultural decision, not an assurance that complete information about every individual has been preserved.

Generational Succession and the Foreshadowing of New Planting

Chapter [–70], "Planting the Channā Grove," connects the collective remembrance following the epidemic to planting trees in physical space. While reading the present chapter, one can perceive a foreshadowing of that transformation, though the future event has not yet occurred within Chapter [–71]. Here names and voices dominate; in the next chapter, the possibility of leaving a mark on the earth is proposed. Across this sequence, memory moves from words to shared sound, and potentially from sound to geography. The pre-narrative links the origin of new cultural institutions into a series. Their external historical reality must nevertheless remain unasserted without independent research.

An Inventory of Contradictions: What Is Resolved and What Remains

The major critical tensions should be named clearly. First, the text uses a figure of seventeen deaths yet ends with a broad refusal of counting.

Second, it insists upon the uniqueness of names while withholding most actual names of those who died in the epidemic. Third, it organizes a daily public gathering alongside the advice to isolate patients, without explaining their practical reconciliation. Fourth, it proclaims deaths "across all quarters, without distinction," without detailed evidence concerning unequal harm to different communities. Fifth, the folk song claims that every body carries a story, while the prose finds it necessary to suspend extended individual narration. These are not all the same kind of factual error: some are moral tensions, others narrative compression, gaps in evidence, or unresolved practical questions.

Final Critical Judgment: The Value of Changing a Method

"The Night of the Epidemic" is an effective turning point in the trilogy's account of the origins of cultural institutions. Fear of an unnamed illness, deaths spreading from a small household to the whole village, Vimalā's question, Burhbā's self-revision, the physician's efforts, and the collective calls at dawn bring the institutional difficulty of respecting each person into sharp relief. The chapter's achievement is to separate the ethical obligation of remembrance from the number of words devoted to it, proposing an alternative form of collective mourning in a crisis. Its limitations are that catastrophic loss is condensed into summary, the independent voices of the dead are scarce, the reasoning against counting remains incomplete, and the practical reconciliation of public health with communal assembly goes unexplained. The literary judgment is conditionally positive: powerfully humane and institutionally imaginative, the chapter should not receive an unexamined endorsement that ignores its own conceptual tensions.

Verified Short Quotations and Distinctions between Textual Levels

Among the important formulations in the original chapter are: "The epidemic took bodies, not the song" (opening proverb); "With each body, a story" (folk song); "Seventeen lives were lost in one week" (Vimalā's dialogue); "This method was not made for this outbreak" (Burhbā's dialogue); "Collective Remembrance" (name of the new institution); "The depth of love cannot be measured by the number of words" (Burhbā's statement); "a slave to counting"; and "Numbers are forgotten; names are not" (closing dialogue). These brief phrases have been considered according to their distinct status as proverb, song, narrative declaration, and character speech. The opening song is not an independent historical report on the epidemic's events, and the post-chapter commentary remains an explanatory paratext, not evidence within the narrated action.

Source Limits, Textual Quantities, and the Next Review

Primary source: Gajendra Thakur, Jal Samadhi Among the Crocodiles, complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter [−71], "The Night of the Epidemic," contents-derived pages 233–236. Secondary source: the entry for [−71] in the earlier "Original Maithili Manuscript"; its previously reported measures are 750 word units and 47.1 percent action-indicative paragraphs (moderate). That proportion has not been independently recalculated here and is not itself a measure of actual event density. The sources provide no pathogen, definite historical date, clinical dataset, total village population, or complete real names of the deceased. No additional assertions from external history or contemporary medicine have been introduced. The next chapter is [−70], "Planting the Channā Grove," to be examined for trees of memory, the living archive, and the institutionalization of ecology.

Critical Section 31 | Original Chapter −70 — Planting the Channā Grove

The Prehistory · A source-based narratological examination of events, ecological time, the geography of memory, and textual incongruities

Textual Boundaries and the Critical Focus

The table of contents gives page 237 as the beginning of Chapter [−70], "Planting the Channā Grove," and page 241 as the beginning of the following chapter, [−69]. Its estimated printed extent is therefore pages 237–240; this does not establish the individual page location of each quotation. The opening proverb, the folk song "The Seed of the Witness-Tree," the prose narrative following the epidemic, and the interpretive commentary entitled "The Concept of the Forest of Memory" constitute distinct textual levels. The central concern of this critique is the emergence of a new geographical place, the commemorative observance associated with it, and the expansion of Burhbā's embodied existence.

After the Epidemic: Inscribing Names upon the Earth

In Chapter [−71], Vimalā instituted the collective calling of names because it had become impossible to give every person who died an extended account and an individual melody immediately. Her next question is whether names should leave a durable mark upon the earth instead of being merely spoken. The epidemic has left numerous families with an absence in their midst; the proposal to plant trees seeks to transform that emptiness into a publicly recognizable place. It would be mistaken to regard this as decorative greenery alone. It constitutes a transformation of the medium through which collective remembrance occurs. Yet the mere planting of a tree does not, without further means, preserve an individual's complete story: the narrative supplies no independent warrant for that conclusion.

The Proverb's Sense of Time: Roots First, Leaves Afterwards

The opening proverb declares that a planted tree does not give shade in a single day, and that roots take hold before leaves appear. Its ethical discipline is patience. Planting is an immediately visible action; shade is an outcome dependent upon time. Roots remain concealed while leaves become visible, an opposition that suggests a difference between the inward establishment of a social institution and its public recognition. The proverb, however, should not be converted into a scientific timetable of botanical growth. In the chapter, the grove actually develops over several

years and generations, so that the proverb's insistence on patience corresponds to the sequence of events.

"The Seed of the Witness-Tree": A Song That Declares the Future Certain

The planting song imagines the work of sowing, water, soil, and the shade that will shelter successive generations. But it also says that the newly planted tree will remain standing for twelve hundred years. This is an emphatic prediction in poetry, not evidence of an already established lifespan. The reader must not assume that twelve hundred years have passed since the particular act of planting being narrated. The opening song accords prestige in advance to a future history, whose temporal meaning must be tested against the much larger chronology of the novel. Its temporal hyperbole heightens emotional anticipation; it does not replace historical proof.

The Song's "This Peepal" and the Prose Narrative's Channā: A Botanical Incongruity

The folk song declares, in effect, that "this peepal" will remain the witness to every joy and sorrow. The prose, however, explicitly distinguishes three kinds of tree: the peepal is already Burhbā's dwelling, the coconut signifies the identity of the village, and a third kind is needed for the new observance. An elderly cultivator then proposes the channā, and the first channā is planted north of the old peepal. No biological transformation of the new channā into a peepal is depicted. If the song uses "peepal" as a general metaphor for a witness-tree, a figurative interpretation is possible; literally, though, it blurs the distinction between the new channā and the established peepal. Criticism must record that incongruity rather than silently identifying the channā as a species of peepal.

How the Tree Is Selected: Vimalā, Burhbā, and the Cultivator

Vimalā proposes the plan. Burhbā accepts its communal significance but asks which tree should be planted. An elderly farmer, who has travelled to distant places, recommends the channā. The three stages separate distinct contributions to institution-building: proposal, a pertinent question, and an option grounded in experience. The farmer is not named, nor does the text provide his village, itinerary, agricultural studies, or a scientific identification of the channā. He describes rapid growth, thick shade, and the rustling of leaves at night. His account should therefore be read as the recommendation of an experienced character accepted within the fictional world—not as an independently verified botanical classification.

The Botanical Identity of "Channā": What the Source Does Not Establish

The prose attributes to the channā tree the rustling of leaves at night, relatively rapid growth, and the capacity to provide shade. It supplies no scientific name, detailed leaf morphology, description of fruit or flowers, geographical origin, or list of local synonyms. These details are insufficient to identify a particular real-world species with certainty. Within the narrative, the tree serves as a vehicle for commemorative practice. Determining its botanical identity outside the narrative would require separate research. The use of the word "channā" in a fictional chapter does not in itself establish the existence of a verified botanical species bearing that name.

Water, Soil, and Time: Nonhuman Collaboration

The song places the seed in soil, gives it water, and envisages the extension of roots and the emergence of leaves. The farmer's speech in the prose mentions shade and the sound of foliage, but the chapter does not elaborate an actual irrigation method, soil composition, rainfall regime, or scarcity of water. Vegetative growth takes time, and the community's work of remembrance may depend on continuous maintenance. That interpretation must arise from what is written, however, not from an invented irrigation system. The tree is more than an inert symbol: it becomes one medium through which Burhbā experiences his own enlargement.

Vimalā's Proposal: A Separate Tree for Every Family

Vimalā proposes planting one tree for every family lost during the epidemic. She also wishes to include the memories of Hulāsā and Jīvantī, Sukhdev and Ratnā, Gangeś and Mālatī, and Anurādhā and Gopīnāth. The proposal thus brings past suffering and past happiness into the same project of preservation. Its scale is ambitious; the number of families, the total number of trees, the available land, and the allocation of future responsibilities remain unspecified. Vimalā offers an initial ethical resolution, not a fully worked-out plan of execution.

The First Tree's Collective Dedication: A Difference between Plan and Action

After Vimalā's desire to plant a separate tree for each family, the narrator states that the first channā was planted in the combined memory of all families who died in the epidemic. A one-tree-per-family intention and an initially collective dedication are not the same thing. The first tree could have inaugurated a sequence of later individual plantings; equally,

the practice might have undergone a practical modification. The novel does not supply a complete list showing that a separate tree was subsequently planted for each bereaved family. The distinction should be noted without inventing a meeting, an amendment to the proposal, or an unreported resolution.

The First Three Plantings: A Directional Geography of Memory

The first channā is placed immediately north of the old peepal; the second, dedicated to Hulāsā, is planted towards the well; the third, dedicated to Jīvantī, towards the pond. These three directional references transform the scene from an abstract repository of memories into a physical landscape the reader can begin to map mentally. The well and pond are sources of water, but their flow, water quality, ownership, and surrounding ecosystems are not described in detail here. "Towards the well" and "towards the pond" do not establish precise compass bearings or allow the critic to fabricate an exact geographical map.

The First Channā: The Epidemic's Collective Dead

The first tree commemorates the families who died in the epidemic as a group. In the previous chapter, Vimalā responded to the difficulty of reciting separate extended histories by introducing a collective call; here a single tree makes that collective act tangible. Yet the category "family" leaves open how each deceased individual within a family receives independent recognition. The tree is unquestionably a sign of respect, but it does not by itself preserve every name, count, or distinctive biography. The commitment to shared remembrance is compelling; the earlier tension between brevity and individuality remains unresolved.

Hulāsā and Jīvantī: Giving Suffering a Place

The second tree, near the well, is assigned to Hulāsā; the third, in the direction of the pond, to Jīvantī. Characters who suffered in the early chapters of the larger narrative now acquire commemorative points in the village's lived geography. Paths, places associated with water, and common shade become readable in relation to their names. The chapter does not, however, explain precisely why these particular sites are connected with the women's life events. A critic must not invent a death or a private conversation at the well or pond. The achievement lies in attaching names to places; the particular significance of each chosen site would require additional textual evidence.

Sukhdev, Ratnā, and Other Figures of Remembrance

As time passes, additional trees are said to commemorate Sukhdev, Ratnā, Gangeś–Mālatī, Sonmā the fisherwoman, Yaśpati, and Anurādhā–

Gopīnāth. The list brings together people of different social positions, kinds of labor, relationships, and moral complexity. But the text does not stage separate planting ceremonies for each person, identify witnesses, describe commemorative plaques, or allocate responsibility for care. The narrator compresses the work of multiple generations into a short statement. The resulting topographical list is a structural symbol of history rather than an independent account of each individual life.

Yaśpati's Small Tree on the Margin: Unequal Inclusion

The tree dedicated to Yaśpati is described as the smallest and the one furthest towards the edge of the grove, a marker of "complex remembrance." The arrangement makes room for a person whose name is neither erased nor accorded identical central honor. The chapter does not explain the discussion, judgment, or full history of wrongdoing that determined this placement. It would be unwarranted to insert incidents absent from the text. The critical issue is whether admission into the collective memory necessarily means equal distinction: here the placement of a tree visually embodies a social judgment.

The Moral Classification of the Grove: Equality and Distance

The trees occupy unequal positions. The old peepal remains the center; the epidemic tree stands to its north; Hulāsā is associated with the direction of the well; Jīvantī with the pond; Yaśpati with the periphery. Memory becomes more than an undifferentiated list: the grove represents centrality and marginality, esteem and hesitation, shared and individual experience. A reading informed by Videha Parallel History asks whose names stand along central communal paths and whose remain near the boundary. Yaśpati's minor place might express moral discrimination, but without fuller context it could also function as exclusion. The text leaves that ambiguity for further evidence to address.

Gangeś and Mālatī: Personal History beyond Scholarly Reputation

The commemorative plan again invokes Gangeś and Mālatī as a couple. Chapter [–72], concerning the marriage of Anurādhā and Gopīnāth, had asked why histories remember intellectual achievement while forgetting private relationships. A tree here gives material form to the wish that their relationship should be remembered. Mālatī's name joins that of Gangeś rather than vanishing beneath his philosophical prestige. This can be read as a protest against the archival invisibility of women. Nevertheless, the fictional planting does not furnish historical evidence about an actual marriage of the historical Gangeś Upādhyāya; it belongs to the novel's internal order of remembrance.

A Tree for the Joyful Marriage of Anurādhā and Gopīnāth

The grove commemorates more than pain and death. The later list includes a tree for the "joyful marriage" of Anurādhā and Gopīnāth. The celebratory drum melody of Chapter [–72] thereby acquires a spatial counterpart. A community committed to preserving life cannot write its history solely as a catalogue of deaths and injustices; it must also acknowledge love and moments of successful social acceptance. The chapter does not specify whether this tree was planted at the time of the wedding or years later in its memory. Its chronology should therefore remain open rather than be fixed by supposition.

The Grove's Gradual Emergence: A Generational Process, Not a Single Ceremony

Expressions such as "one by one, year after year" and "in the course of time" establish the temporal organization of the chapter. The village does not create the entire grove at one meeting. The first communal planting is followed by the addition of commemorations across events, individuals, and generations. The number of years, generations, and trees is not given. The narrative reaches the finished grove rapidly, without placing the prolonged work of planting, watering, guarding, and monitoring growth directly before the reader. Compression gives the institution historical scope while reducing the detail of its environmental life.

The Village Names the Place: Geography Becomes an Institution of Memory

When the channā trees spread around the peepal, the villagers begin calling the place the "Channā Grove." Naming constitutes social recognition within the story: the group of trees becomes a recognizable part of the village's geography. Planting, the formation of an actual grove, and communal naming are three different stages. No government map, revenue record, or official registry is said to contain the name. "Permanent geography" therefore means a place established in the community's habits and understanding, not an independently confirmed administrative designation. The symbolic achievement stands without that additional claim.

The Peepal's Centrality: The Single Heart of Memory

The final account says that "the peepal was its heart." Burhbā's older witness-tree thus remains the center of the expanded commemorative landscape. The grove is not a new institution that abolishes the old one; rather, new growth surrounds the original living memorial. In Chapter [–74] the peepal's disease exposed the bodily fragility of the witness. Here a

larger ensemble offers the imaginative possibility of a less concentrated basis for continuity. But "heart" is a metaphor for the center of communal memory, not literally a biological organ. The rules of Burhbā's unusual existence cannot be derived from that metaphor alone.

Rustling at Night: The Significance of an Audible Forest

The farmer describes channā leaves rustling at night. Later the narrator says the whole grove sounds "as if every tree were whispering its own story." The qualifying expression "as if" matters: the sound of leaves is not demonstrated to be a literal recitation of identifiable histories. Yet this auditory imagery connects the earlier tradition of melodies associated with Mohan to an environment that produces sound without human musical performance. The grove can be encountered by hearing as well as by seeing and reading. Its wordless sound, however, is not equivalent to the complete life history of the particular person to whom a tree is dedicated.

From "One Tree" to "An Entire Grove": Burhbā's Expansion

Burhbā tells Vimalā, "Earlier I was one tree. Now I am an entire grove." The declaration marks an important change in the magical ontology of the fictional world. His existence had previously been understood as tied to the old peepal; he now senses his presence in the individual channā trees and their roots. This is not a verified biological expansion but the supernatural character's reported experience, which the narrator does not contradict. The story replaces a single-point witness with an image of dispersed mnemonic existence. Nevertheless, expressions equivalent to "it seems" retain an element of experiential uncertainty. The declaration is narratively significant without constituting a finding in environmental science.

Distributing the Body: A New Image of Security for Memory

The peepal's illness in Chapter [−74] had revealed how dependent the witness was upon one physical support. Planting additional trees around it suggests a way of lessening that vulnerability: several sets of roots might provide more resilience than a single trunk. But this is a conditional change within the fictional world. The chapter does not specify whether Burhbā's expanded presence becomes independently sustainable in each tree or whether he could survive the complete destruction of the original peepal. Multiplicity is presented as a possible protection for remembrance; the complete removal of risk is not established.

Vimalā's Question: Security and Weakness

When Burhbā speaks of his expanded body, Vimalā asks whether it gives him strength or makes him weak. The question declines to accept a

supernatural self-description without examination. His answer—"perhaps both"—looks paradoxical at first but admits the interconnected vulnerabilities of living systems. More trees mean more roots, more relationships, and more possible supports; they also mean additional organisms that can become ill or require care. Although Burhbā emphasizes increased safety, his "perhaps" leaves the reader short of certainty. The dialogue acknowledges both the benefits and the costs of an expanding institution.

"A Whole Grove Is Never Entirely Destroyed at Once": The Limits of Generalization

Burhbā argues that an individual tree may become diseased or fall in a storm but that an entire grove is "never" destroyed completely at one time. This is a character's confident generalization, not an independently established law. Fire, drought, widespread infection, damage to root systems, and other collective disasters are not excluded from the fictional world. It is reasonable to suppose that several supports may be less vulnerable than one; it is not justified to infer universal indestructibility. In the terminology of Navya-Nyāya, the necessary invariable relation between the example and the unrestricted claim remains unproved.

The Survival of Roots and the Survival of Memory

Burhbā says that somewhere in the grove "some root or other will always remain." Roots suggest biological continuity, but what actually sustains cultural knowledge? A community may forget whose memory a tree embodies even while that tree remains alive. A tree becomes an active mnemonic record only when people can connect it with names, melodies, and narratives. The story imagines these links being maintained through reverence and recollection. Criticism must foreground the community capable of "reading" the site; without its interpretive work, a tree could remain simply a tree.

Nonhuman Agency: Trees Are Not Merely Scenery

The channā trees grow, rustle, shade the ground, and extend their roots; these processes have consequences for the story. As the grove develops, Burhbā's sense of his own existence changes. The nonhuman environment therefore actively shapes a social institution rather than serving as decorative background. Yet the trees' independent "wishes" are not narrated as direct facts. Some expressions personify the trees by saying "as if," while the farmer's account of leaf-rustling and Burhbā's supernatural experience belong to distinct levels of representation. Ecocriticism must distinguish botanical processes, personification, and the magical rules of the story.

The Uneven Visibility of Labor: Who Planted, and Who Tended?

The planting song speaks of placing seeds in soil, giving water, tending the saplings, and joining the village's hands. The prose identifies the locations of the first three plantings but gives relatively little space to the workers, those who carried water, the distribution of agricultural labor, guarding the young trees, or the effect on livelihoods. "The village's hands" is a powerful figure for unity but offers little evidence for assessing inequalities of caste, gender, or occupation in the work itself. Videha Parallel History asks who owns such memorials and who maintains them. The chapter does not supply enough detail to answer those questions; the critic must not invent it.

The Unasked Question of Land Rights

The grove expands "around the peepal," but the story does not say who held rights over this land, what crops or activities had previously occupied it, or whose consent allowed the permanent establishment of a memorial forest. The village is represented as an ethical community sharing a common space. Yet land is a finite material resource; its use for a large commemorative institution necessarily raises questions of ownership and allocation. The absence of such detail must not be turned into an allegation of land seizure. It is enough to recognize that the economic and proprietary conditions of this aesthetically appealing communal project remain outside the narrated events.

The Labor of Water: Active in the Song, Less Visible in the Prose

The planting song enjoins the community to give water and imagines future shade. Water is thus an indispensable companion to the symbolism of growth. The prose establishes directions towards the well and pond but does not describe the frequency of irrigation, episodes of shortage, flood damage, silt, or the distribution of the pond's water. Soil and water remain possible material conditions of nonhuman agency, not a fully documented history of water management. Their imagery may acquire greater meaning in later accounts of aquatic catastrophe, but the present chapter does not authorize an invented environmental works program.

Traditional Knowledge and the Experience of Travel

The person who recommends the channā is an elderly cultivator who has travelled widely. His introduction makes room for agricultural observation and contact with the wider world in a local decision. Burhbā asks; the cultivator answers. The exchange portrays cooperation rather than a hierarchy in which one kind of knowledge automatically displaces another. But the farmer's advice is not accompanied by trials of climatic suitability, resistance to disease, or evidence about the locations in which

the tree grows. His recommendation is an experienced character's view accepted in the story, not a legally or scientifically certified conclusion in modern botany. Nor may it be represented as the considered agreement of all local agricultural workers.

The Work-Rhythm of the Planting Song and the Prose's Accelerated Summary

The song repeatedly invokes planting, watering, tending, and patience. The repetition of these verbs conveys the regular recurrence of necessary labor. The prose, by contrast, traverses several years within a few sentences. Thus the song gives emotional duration to continued care while the prose abbreviates the sequence of events. Their different narrative tempos can complement each other. Nevertheless, the activities instructed by the song are not automatically equivalent to actions demonstrably completed in the story: "be patient and water the trees" is a ritual exhortation, not an authenticated record of every tree being watered daily.

An Origin Story: An Etiological Technique of Narration

A number of sections in the prehistory account for the origin of later local customs, musical practices, or place names. "Planting the Channā Grove" is a clear example of this etiological technique: a need for commemoration following the epidemic leads to Vimalā's proposal, the farmer's choice of tree, the first planting, expansion across generations, and public naming. The resulting place acquires a narrated past instead of remaining merely a point on a map. Every tree can evoke an earlier event. The limitation is that the whole development proceeds with unusual regularity towards its ethical goal; disagreement, failed plantings, incomplete plans, and contingent setbacks scarcely figure in the sequence.

Prolepsis and the Promise of Future Recognition

An introductory textual remark tells a future reader that the Channā Grove will appear "much later" in the work. The prose presently narrates the grove's origin. The arrangement links a site familiar to a future narrative world with the historical moment of its foundation. This anticipatory viewpoint belongs to a narrator who knows the larger narrative trajectory; Vimalā does not thereby know all subsequent events. Separating the narrator's later knowledge from a character's present decision is essential. The promise of future recognition magnifies the narrative significance of what initially appears to be a modest planting.

Narrator and Focalization: From External Account to Burhbā's Experience

The third-person narrative initially describes Vimalā, the farmer, and the village's actions from outside. At the point when Burhbā senses himself extending into the grove, the narration moves closer to his internal experience—as if he no longer existed in just one tree. Burhbā's first-person speech then interprets that experience. This shift makes both the physical expansion of the trees and the supernatural character's feeling of enlargement accessible to the reader. But an "as if" comparison, a character's impression, and the narrator's retrospective summary are not identical forms of evidence. Keeping them separate is indispensable to understanding the internal rules of the novel's magical realism.

Temporal Scale: One Planting and the Life of Many Generations

The planting of the first tree is rendered almost as an immediate event, whereas the development of the entire grove is compressed into expressions such as "year after year" and "every generation." The biological life of numerous trees is reduced to a short narrated interval. Many acts are asserted to have occurred without becoming individually staged scenes. It is useful to distinguish density of events from density of ideas: the chapter attends most closely to the institution's founding and expansion, and much less to the daily struggles of those whose labor sustains it.

The Sequence of Memory-Places: Peepal, Channā, and Pond

The old peepal constitutes one center; the Channā Grove extends from it; the direction of the pond marks another remembered setting, and the well provides a further point of orientation. The relationships of the village's history acquire a network of visible places. The chapter, however, does not establish the grove's exact distance from the paired pond, the roads or paths connecting them, the property boundaries, or river-related changes in the land. Its achievement is to create a mental map, not to furnish the measurements for a precise survey. Events belonging to different periods are gathered within the same setting; the grove becomes a conjunction of narrative time and place.

"A Living Library": Reading without Letters

The closing metaphor calls the grove "a living library" that can supposedly be read without letters, requiring only reverence and memory. The metaphor accords dignity to forms of popular understanding that exist beyond written documents. Yet knowing whom a tree commemorates still requires the transmission of names, relationships, stories, and interpretive traditions. Reverence alone will not disclose every historical fact. Against

the established background of the coconut-leaf school and written records, reading this landscape without letters and reading formal documents may be complementary practices. They need not be mutually exclusive or interchangeable.

The Letterless Library and the Problem of Evidence

The phrase "only reverence and memory" clarifies the grove's folk-cultural significance but does not explain how contradictory accounts are assessed. If two groups associate a particular tree with different names, how is the disagreement resolved? The narrative does not stage such a dispute. In Navya-Nyāya terms, a tree can be perceived as a physical object, but the knowledge that it is dedicated to a particular person ordinarily derives from testimony, tradition, or inscription. Without this epistemic distinction, the witness-tree could mistakenly be treated as an infallible literal knower of every past event. The novel's metaphor vividly expresses the worth of remembrance while leaving its complete verification procedures undeveloped.

Each Tree's Own Melody: Folk Music and Commemorative Place

The closing description assigns each tree its own story, name, and "melody," said to have been composed by Mohan's descendants. In this way the mourning-melody tradition of Chapter [–73] and the wedding melody of [–72] acquire a possible home in the landscape. Yet this chapter does not describe which melody was actually played near each tree, by which musician, on what instrument, or in what sequence. The musical statement summarizes a cultural system rather than staging every performance. The natural rustling of foliage and melodies produced by human musicians also have different origins and must not be treated as the same audible event.

External Claims about Memorial Forests and the Paratext

The author's commentary following the chapter makes the broad claim that tree planting as memorial practice occurs in "many cultures of the world." This is an interpretive paratext, not an event in the imaginary village, and it does not itself constitute a documented worldwide cultural survey. Reliable comparisons would require independently verified sources. The present criticism primarily examines the internal operation of the novel. A wider comparative study might use the commentary as a starting point, but its generalization must remain distinct from the specific events represented in the fictional story.

Indian Poetics: From *Karuṇa* to *Adbhuta*

Remembering the families who died in the epidemic provides a background of karuṇa, the pathetic or compassionate mood. Planting new trees becomes a support for hope; the nocturnal description of trees seeming to whisper arouses adbhuta, wonder. Burhbā's expanded body is the central supernatural image. No single mood rules uninterruptedly: grief, enthusiasm, astonishment, and patience develop in succession. In analyzing this aesthetic movement, the characters' actual experiences must be distinguished from the suggested meaning of metaphors. Yaśpati's small peripheral tree introduces moral hesitation into the communal harmony; the scene therefore does not settle into an unquestioned state of peace.

Dhvani and Propriety: The Social Meaning of the Planting Song

A planting song is well suited to an undertaking involving soil, water, labor, seasons, and patience. The phrase "roots first" suggests the unseen groundwork of an institution; shade suggests shared protection; the seed implies trust in later generations. The choice of folk-song form is therefore appropriate to the episode. Still, the song's use of "peepal" while the prose distinguishes the "channā" creates a genuine difficulty of narrative propriety. Recognizing the metaphorical breadth of the song does not require the critic to suppress its imprecise correspondence with the trees actually named in the prose.

A Navya-Nyāya Question: Whom Does a Tree's "Name" Designate?

Some trees commemorate one individual, another commemorates many families, and some stand for relationships between couples. There is thus no uniform equivalence of one tree to one person. The relationship between tree and person is established through a social act of dedication; a tree is not the person it commemorates. Saying "X's tree" might ordinarily signify ownership, a birthplace, a place of burial, or a cultural dedication. In this chapter, memorial dedication predominates. Clear delimitation of the relationship prevents a symbolic assignment from being mistaken for biological identity or a legal claim to property.

Testing the Inference: More Trees Mean More Durable Memory?

Burhbā's reasoning is that one tree can die but that the greater number of roots in a grove will safeguard the whole memorial existence. The reduction of risk through multiple supports is plausible, but the mere presence of "many" supports does not prove immortality. Under a Navya-Nyāya inquiry one must ask whether an event could damage the whole grove simultaneously, and whether every tree contains all the memories or only those specifically dedicated to it. The cultural effect of losing a single tree would differ under these two possibilities. Since the story does not

settle them, Burhbā's conclusion is best treated as a hopeful inference rather than a universal law.

Vimalā's Institutional Agency: A Policy of Expansion

In the epidemic chapter Vimalā had created collective calling as a way to remember many people under conditions of extreme loss. Here she develops the further possibility of marking names upon the land. Her leadership does more than conserve a practice: it repeatedly redesigns the medium of remembrance. Burhbā contributes questions and guidance, but the initiating conception is hers. Other women's work or decision-making within the planting enterprise is not described at comparable length. Vimalā's agency is strongly established; the equal representation of all women in the community is not thereby proved.

The Grove's "Sacredness" and the Right to Question

At the end, the Channā Grove is described as the village's "holiest" and "most important" place. This is a strong valuation by the narrator; no dissenting group or independent religious debate is staged. Sacredness can be understood here as the result of respect for the dead, planting across generations, and Burhbā's transformed sense of existence. Yet the practical questions remain: who confers sacred status, who may enter, who decides on its use, and who is responsible for its upkeep? Sacred places can promote participation; in some circumstances claims of sanctity may also restrict it. The latter possibility is a critical question, not an event shown in the present text.

The Meeting of Magical Realism and Social Materiality

Burhbā's expanded body is a supernatural element; its emergence nevertheless depends upon ordinary actions—planting trees, proposing their care, letting roots spread, and giving a site a name. Their conjunction is the creative power of the chapter's magical realism. Collective memory stretches beyond an individual body, yet it cannot do so without soil and living vegetation. It would be mistaken either to turn the miracle into verified natural science or to dismiss the tangible labor of planting as a decoration supplied for magic. The novel imagines interdependence among people, plants, and the being that guards memory at both ideological and experiential levels.

A Systematic Account of the Chapter's Principal Incongruities

The first textual discrepancy is botanical: the song names the new witness-tree a peepal, while the prose clearly separates channā from the old peepal. Second, the song's assurance of twelve hundred years expresses a future hope, not an already demonstrated history. Third, Vimalā wishes to plant a

separate tree for every bereaved family, whereas the first actual planting commemorates all such families collectively. Fourth, Burhbā's claim that a whole grove can "never" be utterly destroyed exceeds the evidence of his conditional examples. Fifth, the "living library" supposedly needs no letters although interpreting its dedications requires transmitted cultural information. Sixth, the peripheral position of Yaśpati's small tree leaves unsettled the question of equal dignity in communal remembrance. Language, time, action, inference, and ethics require different kinds of scrutiny here; they should not all be reduced to one category of error.

Overall Critical Judgment: Memory Becomes Geography

The principal achievement of "Planting the Channā Grove" is that the practice of "saving names" advances from leaves, voices, and observances into a communal geography of soil, roots, and shade. Vimalā's initiative, Burhbā's questions, a travelled farmer's proposal, the placing of commemorative trees, Yaśpati's marginal position, and Burhbā's extended arboreal body together create a compelling origin story. Limitations remain: a vast generational expansion is narrated in summary; the labor and land questions are thinly developed; botanical identity is uncertain; and the claim of complete indestructibility is poorly grounded. The confusion between "peepal" and "channā" deserves specific critical attention. The literary assessment is conditionally positive: the commemorative grove is an evocative, intertextually rich invention, but its social and environmental plausibility must be assessed without suppressing exaggeration or gaps.

Sources, Evidentiary Limits, and Transition to the Next Chapter

The primary text is Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, the complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter [–70], "Planting the Channā Grove," pages 237–240 according to the contents. The proverb "A planted tree does not give shade in a day," the folk song "The Seed of the Witness-Tree," the conversations among Vimalā, Burhbā, and the old farmer, and the final account of the "living library" are examined at their distinct textual levels. The author's subsequent commentary, "The Concept of the Forest of Memory," is interpretative paratext, not independent evidence of external history. The figures mentioned there had already been recorded; this criticism has not independently recalculated them. No verified botanical identification of the channā, total number of trees, precise planting years, or independent historical documentation is supplied. The next study, Chapter [–69], "The Tale of the Elephant and the Crocodile," examines the intertextual presence of the Purāṇic Gajendra-mokṣa story, a genuine crisis at the paired pond, collective rescue, and the narrative role of the "Original Crocodile."

Critical Section 32 | Original Chapter −69 — The Tale of the Elephant and the Crocodile

The Prehistory · Purāṇic intertext, a crisis involving aquatic life, evidentiary reasoning, and a community acting together

Textual Extent, Form, and the Central Critical Proposition

Chapter [−69], "The Tale of the Elephant and the Crocodile," is an event-centered episode of the prehistory. The original contents place its opening on page 241 and the next chapter's opening on page 245; pages 241–244 are therefore the estimated printed range, not separately confirmed page numbers for each sentence. The opening proverb, the folk song "Deliverance Through Calling the Name," the prose account of the living elephant Gajarāj's peril, and the commentary entitled "The Confluence of the Gajendra-mokṣa Story and Local Folk Tradition" are four distinct textual layers. The main critical question is how far the interpretation advanced by invoking an ancient tale actually corresponds to the work performed during the present emergency.

The figures and classifications noted in the planning material are not independent counts made anew for this criticism and do not represent a final enumeration of events. Nor does the story contain a formal gathering for philosophical disputation or an extended debate among many classical positions. It presents an elderly scholar's recollection of a Purāṇic narrative, Burhbā's partially accepting but corrective reply, and collective action. Thus the planned term "śāstrārtha" cannot be treated as evidence of a debate scene absent from the novel. The appropriate object of study is the shorter argumentative succession of proposition, qualification, and action.

The Narrative Opening: The Transfer of Responsibility from Vimalā to Sūryanāth

The prose first states that after Vimalā the duty of maintaining the observance passed to her son Sūryanāth. One sentence connects the collective remembrance instituted in Chapter [−71] and the grove established in [−70] to the next generation of communal responsibility. It does not say how many years Sūryanāth held that responsibility before the crisis, whether Vimalā had died, or whether a change of custodian occurred for another reason. "After Vimalā" must not automatically be converted into a death notice or a precise chronology. Sūryanāth is initially defined by his public office; his interior life, familial relationships, and history of labor receive comparatively little space.

Gajarāj's Double Existence: A Living Elephant and a Religious Symbol

The village temple maintains an elephant called Gajarāj for festive processions. The first action in this episode is a living animal escaping its mahout and going to drink water. The crisis therefore begins not with an abstract theological emblem but with bodily thirst and independent movement. The name Gajarāj recalls the Gajendra narrative in the Purāṇas, but the animal is not thereby established to be the mythic Gajendra himself. His service to a temple, human control over his movements, and his role in festivals raise questions of animal ethics and work. The text gives no detailed account of his husbandry, health, or the mahout's care; no unreported abuse should be invented to fill the gap.

An Afternoon in the Hot Season: Brief Action against Mythic Duration

The present danger begins on "a summer afternoon." Gajarāj enters the deeper part of the paired pond to drink; a sudden disturbance of the water, cries, and the seizing of his leg accelerate the action. In the song and the old scholar's Purāṇic recollection, the struggle lasts for years or thousands of years. The present elephant's ordeal is described only as extending through a "long struggle" before he is rescued, not as lasting years. The contrast places the seemingly endless waiting of myth beside the urgency of rescue in the village. Their narrative scales are comparable as patterns, but their reported durations are not identical.

The Paired Pond: Physical Risk and Narrative Setting

The paired pond is already familiar within the fictional world. Its deeper water, turbulence, and the presence of a large crocodilian creature make this incident possible. The pond is not passive scenery: the animal's need to drink, its entrapment in the deeper part, and the rescue from the shore depend upon its physical configuration. Yet the text provides no exact measurements of depth or gradient, seasonal water levels, or plan of the banks. Technical explanation should remain within the source's account of ropes, bamboo, angles, and pressure; a detailed engineering diagram of the rescue would be invented evidence.

The Crocodile's Attack: Keeping an Unknown Cause Unknown

The narrator specifically says that the enormous gohi had not touched an animal for a long time because of the offering tradition established by Sonmā the fisherwoman, but on this occasion it seized the elephant's leg "for some unknown reason." The long-standing practice and its present exception coexist within the story. The precise biological or social cause of the attack is not disclosed. Hunger, anger, a broken ritual, or divine

punishment must not be added as if narrated fact. The narrator attributes the earlier absence of attacks to the offering custom, but no separate causal mechanism is demonstrated. This is a relationship posited within the narrative world, not a verified law of animal behavior.

Sonmā the Fisherwoman's Tradition: The Remembered Presence of a Working Woman

Sonmā does not personally appear in this scene, yet her name provides the background to the long coexistence of the community and the gohi. The reference preserves something of the earlier woman's work, knowledge of water, and ritual offering practice. At the same time, she has no new dialogue here. The speaking roles pass chiefly to the elderly scholar, Burhbā, and Sūryanāth. A question associated with Videha Parallel History therefore arises: once a crisis affects a practice developed through a woman's experience, who is entitled to decide what should happen next? The chapter supplies no independent rescue advice from Sonmā's descendants or other workers familiar with the water.

The Mahout's Fear: The First Direct Appeal for Help

When the elephant becomes trapped, the mahout cries out, "Gajarāj will die!" and asks those nearby to help. This is not initially a question of scripture; it is an alarm over a living being's imminent death. The mahout is presumably closely connected with the elephant's daily care, but no particular technical contribution from him is described in the later rescue scenes. The narrative moves towards the scholar's interpretation, Sūryanāth's urgent appeal, and the youths' physical intervention. This allocation of roles prompts an inquiry into whose practical expertise is heard and whose voice is confined to announcing the danger. The mahout's later narrative silence must not be treated as proof that he fled, objected, or did nothing.

Crowd, Fear, and the First Stage of Collective Inaction

The villagers gather, but initially "no one could summon the courage to do anything." A gathering is thus not the same as an organized capacity to act. The crowd begins as spectators, and Sūryanāth later transforms that collective presence into coordinated assistance. This change is essential to the narrative movement from fear to intervention. The statement does not establish that all participants were identically frightened or that specific proposals were raised and rejected. The narrator presents an initial paralysis to which action becomes the response after the moral intervention associated with Burhbā.

The Elderly Scholar's Recollection of Gajendra-mokṣa: The Entrance of an Exemplum

An elderly scholar familiar with Purāṇic accounts recognizes a resemblance between the present incident and the ancient Gajendra-mokṣa story. His retelling includes the elephant king, prolonged seizure by the crocodile, abandonment of pride, and the arrival of the deity. It is a second narrative embedded within the village's story. The chapter does not give the original Sanskrit verses, their variants, or verse numbers. Consequently, this retelling cannot be called a literal translation of the Bhāgavata Purāṇa or an exhaustive record of its ancient versions. The scholar's function is not to authenticate the myth historically but to supply the anxious crowd with an understanding of prayer.

Deliverance by a God in the Purāṇa and Human Help in the Village

In the scholar's account, the deity intervenes directly to rescue Gajendra. The contemporary story does not depict any god descending into the paired pond or fighting the creature. The young villagers use ropes and bamboo, after which the gohi loosens its grip. It would therefore be incorrect to conclude that the mythic event has simply recurred unchanged. The ancient narrative provides a pattern that inspires communal organization, but the agents visibly undertaking the present rescue are human. Burhbā's statement that prayer and effort both matter gives this modification its philosophical formula. Unless the difference is kept in view, the creative transformation of the source narrative disappears.

Mythic "Thousands of Years" and the Song's "Years Passed"

The folk song says that "years passed" during Gajarāj's struggle. The elderly scholar speaks of a struggle lasting "thousands of years" in the myth. The present incident begins on a summer afternoon and ends after an unspecified period of effort. These are three temporal planes: the song's mythic expansion, the scholar's recalled story, and the prose time of the present episode. The song uses the image of Gajarāj to bring the Purāṇic elephant and the village elephant close together, potentially confusing their identities. Criticism must identify the blending rather than invent an unreported account of the local elephant being trapped for years.

The Elephant's "Calling of a Name" in the Song and the People's Calls in the Prose

A decisive phrase in the song, "then a name was called," is placed close to the elephant, allowing a poetic impression that Gajarāj himself invokes a divine name. The prose presents something different: the elephant cries

and raises its trunk, but does not utter a deity's name or words of the local ritual. The religious calling is performed by the scholar, the gathered women and men, and the people acting under Sūryanāth's direction. The song may suggest an elephant's inner act of faith, while the prose shows human speech and action. The difference cannot be reconciled by inventing miraculous animal language.

Gajarāj's Inner Life: Bodily Signs and Inferred Emotions

What the prose actually represents is the elephant's physical behavior: going down to drink, crying out, raising his trunk, having a leg seized, and reaching the bank in a weakened condition. It does not say that this elephant harbored "pride" or consciously made a religious surrender. Transferring the mental attributes of the mythic Gajendra to this living animal would be an unwarranted reading of his interior life. He survives, though weak. Attaching human concepts not supplied by the story may obscure the seriousness of his bodily danger. From a nonhuman perspective, he should first be understood as a living creature deserving help, not merely as an illustration of sacred doctrine.

Sūryanāth Runs for Help: From Listener to Organizer

After hearing the scholar's account, Sūryanāth runs to the peepal and asks Burhbā what should be done immediately. The run matters dramatically: the recollection of a Purāṇic narrative does not itself release the elephant, but prompts a question addressed to the village's established institution of memory. Following Burhbā's response, Sūryanāth gathers people and divides the work. The text does not specify whether he personally handles a rope or what exact position he assumes at the water's edge; his demonstrated contribution is organization. Leadership here becomes the coordination of collective effort rather than the exclusive bodily heroism of an individual.

Burhbā's Qualified Acceptance: "Right," but "Not Enough Alone"

Burhbā does not dismiss the scholar. He says, in effect, that the scholar is right, yet "prayer alone is not enough." His answer first admits a valid intention and then qualifies it by demanding a complementary means. Cultural reverence and practical rescue need not be represented as antagonists. But the causal indispensability of prayer remains unproved: the novel depicts prayer and the use of equipment together, without comparing the outcomes of assistance alone and prayer alone. Ethical conjunction and demonstrated causal necessity must be separated. The scene offers one successful combined action, not a controlled comparison establishing the necessity of each component in every case.

The Limits of "Reason Alone": An Echo of the Earlier Philosophical Chapters

Burhbā adds that prayer alone is insufficient, "just as reason alone is insufficient." The remark connects the early discussions of illusion and the conch-shell–silver analogy, self-knowledge, and Nyāya to the pressing difficulties of communal life. The intellectual clarification provided by argument must be translated into useful activity when a body is in danger. Yet the villagers' concrete rescue is not devoid of reasoning: the use of ropes, angles, and pressure itself calls for practical judgment. Thus a strict opposition between reason and action does not fit the episode as well as their integration.

The "Original Crocodile" and the Large Creature in the Pond: A Distinction of Designation

The creature gripping the elephant is described as "a large gohi." In their public prayer, the villagers address the "Original Gohi," and a special offering is later made to this same ritual addressee. The chapter does not explicitly establish whether the large animal and the original sacred presence are one and the same being or whether they occupy different conceptual positions in the village's understanding of the water. It would be wrong to add the claim that the particular animal was itself the divine Original Gohi, or that the latter ordered it to seize the elephant. The aquatic creature's visible physical conduct and the religious status of the being invoked in prayer require separate treatment.

Burhbā in "Every Drop" of Water: Another Supernatural Extension

Chapter [–70] expanded Burhbā's sensed presence from the old peepal into the roots of the Channā Grove. Here the narrator says that he was "pervading every drop of water" and therefore had already sensed the crisis. This adds a new aqueous dimension to his supernatural existence. No independent scene explains how this water-pervasion arose, what its limits are, or how it relates to the peepal and the grove's roots. It would be premature to call the extension an absolute contradiction, for a magical world may permit several overlapping media of existence. Nevertheless, the repeated expansion of omnipresence without a clearly stated transition strains the precision of the narrative's internal rules.

Burhbā's Foreknowledge and the Need for Human Questions

The narrator attributes foreknowledge of the danger to Burhbā's presence in every drop of water. Yet practical instructions emerge only after Sūryanāth runs to appeal to him. This raises a fair question: if Burhbā already knew of the danger, why had he not initiated the rescue? The

narrative does not explain his inability or the practical constraints that delayed such action. Foreknowledge, however, is not equivalent to the spontaneous assembly of human rescuers; Sūryanāth still performs a distinct and necessary narrative function. Criticism should indicate the unshown connection without inventing a moral offense of deliberate negligence on Burhbā's part.

Two Sources of Prayer: Purāṇic Verse and the Kabaddi Call

At the pond, the scholar and the village's women and men recite old verses associated with Gajendra alongside the special calls of the kabaddi remembrance observance. The scene brings a scriptural religious tradition and the village's own institution for preserving names into a single public act. But the original chapter does not specify the Sanskrit verse actually recited, its number of repetitions, or the precise rhythm of the common call. Quoting an unprovided śloka or inventing a musical setting would be unjustified. The story depicts the social coexistence of these traditions, not their complete philosophical equivalence.

"Gajarāj Is Ours" and "The Water Is Yours": The Folk Ethics of Rights

The villagers' appeal joins two statements: "Gajarāj belongs to us" and "your own water belongs to you." The combination is remarkable. Human beings claim a communal relationship with the elephant while also acknowledging the water as the domain of another creature or of the locally imagined water-presence. Rather than asserting an unrestricted right to conquer, the language offers recognition and a request. Yet Gajarāj is maintained for temple processions, so "ours" may conflate ownership with a duty of care. Respecting the aquatic creature's presence in the pond, moreover, raises difficult questions when its feeding or defensive behavior endangers another living being. These ethical issues are opened, not fully resolved, by the plea.

The Promise of a Special Offering: The Question of Ritual Exchange

During their appeal, the villagers promise to make "a special offering" that night. After Gajarāj survives, they perform the promised act. The narrative does not identify its substance, who supplies it, who receives it, or its social cost. It would therefore be a fabricated detail to call it an animal sacrifice, fish, grain, or any particular ritual object. The established event is simply the making and honoring of a promise. The offering cannot logically have caused the earlier relaxation of the creature's grip if its performance took place only later in the evening. No independent causal effect of the offering is demonstrated.

Two Forms of Action at Once: The Structure of Simultaneity

Sūryanāth organizes the villagers to perform "two tasks together": prayer and the physical rescue. The timing is important. The chapter does not say that the people completed their prayers and only then began working with ropes. The audible appeals of women and men proceed while strong youths attempt the release with bamboo and rope. The parallel composition creates a sense of communal coordination. But explaining the physical release solely as an effect of the prayer would erase the independence of the actions that are visibly undertaken. Simultaneity produces ethical unity in the narrative; it does not prove that prayer mechanically freed the animal.

Distribution of Labor: Those Who Pray and Those Who Rescue

The text says that the scholar and the village's women and men pray while "strong young men" attempt the rescue with ropes and bamboo. These are the two functional groups explicitly mentioned. The description does not establish that every woman was excluded from using equipment or that all elderly people remained completely inactive. The narrator allocates difficult physical work to male youths while recognizing women as participants in the collective voice. This raises the question of how technical knowledge, bodily authority, and religious speech distribute recognition and credit. No young rescuer is named individually; agency is depicted through organized collective labor.

Rope, Bamboo, Angle, and Pressure: The Action Actually Described

The young men use rope and bamboo, acting "patiently, at an angle, applying pressure," to release the elephant's trapped leg. This is the most concrete account of work in the chapter. It gives content to "effort" beyond the abstract exhortation to act. Nevertheless, the story does not show where the rope is fastened, how the bamboo is positioned, or precisely how the creature's grip is relaxed. The passage must not be treated as a modern animal-rescue technique or a set of safe real-world instructions. Its literary significance is the presence of practical ingenuity, not the provision of a certified rescue manual.

The Aim of Rescue without Violence—and Its Limits

The story says that the youths seek to free Gajarāj without injuring him further and without directly attacking the gohi. The emergency is not converted into a tale of revenge or the annihilation of an enemy. Attempting to preserve the lives of both creatures embodies an ideal of coexistence. But the chapter gives little physical explanation of how such a plan succeeds amid the strength of the grip and the risks of deep water. The action offers an animal-ethical possibility, not proof of a risk-free method.

Avoiding killing is an intelligible moral goal; the success of the rescue remains an outcome governed by the fictional account.

The Moment of Release: Dramatic Delay and an Unknown Cause

"After a long struggle, suddenly," the gohi loosens its grip. The first expression leaves the duration open; the second emphasizes the abruptness of the result. The work of the rescuers precedes the release, but the animal's physical response, fear, exhaustion, or willingness is not independently described. This is the episode's crucial evidentiary gap. The novelist shows freedom following collective effort, and the reader may experience it as the narrative result of that effort. It does not follow that any particular hidden agent or mechanism has been established as the exclusive cause.

"As If It Understood": The Limits of Personification

The creature slips back into deep water, and the narrator adds that it did so "as if it had itself understood that this battle was not for it." The qualification "as if" proposes a comparison, not direct testimony concerning the crocodilian creature's thoughts. Personifying the animal as a being that understands the pointlessness of conflict strengthens the peaceful resolution. But the text does not establish an independent moral transformation, a spiritual act of forgiveness, or a fully articulated intention on the animal's part. The figure should be read as an imagination of nonviolent relations with nonhuman life, not a verified report of animal reasoning.

Gajarāj Reaches the Bank: The Limits of Victory

After the gohi disappears into the water, Gajarāj reaches the bank "weak but alive." The victory is not a declaration of complete recovery; it is the visible survival of an animal who has escaped immediate peril. The narrator gives no subsequent veterinary assessment, treatment of injuries, return to temple processions, or account of his relationship with the mahout after the event. Aesthetic satisfaction should rest on the facts provided: the grip has been released and the elephant has emerged alive. The villagers' rejoicing signifies collective relief, not a complete history of the animal's long-term welfare.

The Mahout's Subsequent Absence: Remembering the Labor Closest to the Animal

The mahout's frightened appeal begins the rescue narrative, but his role does not return to the center of policy, action, or celebration. Someone whose daily work would be closely connected to the temple elephant remains nameless as collective leadership is foregrounded. This is a legitimate point for analyzing uneven representation of labor. It does not

mean the mahout has been proved absent from the actual rescue or that he was cowardly or at fault. The written text simply gives him little further place; the critic may examine that silence without turning it into an invented episode.

The Scholar's Knowledge: Narrative Authority, Not Technical Direction

The elderly scholar recognizes and retells the Gajendra-mokṣa story, giving the frightened crowd a possible meaning for its predicament. He does not devise the rope-and-bamboo method; Burhbā is not represented as a medical or veterinary expert in the modern sense either. The scholar's authority lies in communicating a classical example. The novel does not reject scriptural narration outright but incorporates it into a process requiring practical decisions. The limits of straightforward imitation arise from the difference between the stories: divine intervention in the Purāṇic episode, and human physical work in the village. Any claim that they are literally the same event would obscure their distinct agencies.

The Joint Principle of Prayer and Effort: An Evidentiary Difficulty

Burhbā's final instruction, that "both prayer and effort are needed," offers an ethical generalization. The narrative depicts one successful incident in which both are present. Logically, a successful conjunction alone cannot establish the indispensability of each component in all circumstances. If both accompany a favorable result, the universal necessity of each requires more than this single case. The physical means by which the elephant escaped would require independent scrutiny. Acknowledging this philosophical limit does not diminish the communal significance of prayer; it distinguishes an inspiring moral proposition from a proved universal causal law.

An Abbreviated *Śāstrārtha*: Proposition, Qualification, and Revision

The scholar recalls that the ancient Gajendra was delivered through prayer and proposes prayer in the present crisis. Burhbā accepts the humane intention and adds the need for direct assistance. Sūryanāth organizes the joint undertaking. No independent opponent subsequently examines Burhbā's claim that both components are universally necessary. This is not a decisive full-scale session of philosophical disputation but a compressed exchange prompted by a concrete emergency. Its achievement lies in translating deliberation into action; its limitation is the rapid closure of adversarial questioning.

Reusing the Earlier Kabaddi Ritual

The special public call associated with the kabaddi practice of saving names has already become an established form of village communication. In this emergency, it is sounded at the edge of the pond. The cultural voice of a traditional game thus serves not only remembrance or celebration but also a shared appeal to preserve the life of an animal. Yet the chapter does not stage a kabaddi match, its regulated turns, playing field, or a win-and-loss result. The ritual call and the actual physical game are different actions. Moving the voice into a new setting displays the adaptability of folk culture but does not establish any independent supernatural effectiveness of the call.

The Night Offering: Fulfilling a Promise after the Rescue

The special offering pledged during the emergency is presented that night. The day's danger and the evening act of fulfillment are two distinct times in the story. The villagers take responsibility for what they have said; their promise does not remain merely a device for raising courage during the rescue. But since the form, economic cost, and religious content of the offering are undisclosed, it cannot be identified with the animal's diet or asserted to have prevented subsequent attacks. What is actually narrated is fidelity to a promise; the offering's material effect is unresolved.

The "Original Gohi" in the Main Narrative: Mythic and Ecological Levels

The animal visibly grasping the elephant is a creature of the fictional pond. The "Original Gohi," addressed by the villagers, has the status of a longstanding local ritual presence. Their relationship is suggested but no categorical identity is stated. The ambiguity allows the physical world of aquatic life and the villagers' sacred interpretation of that world to occupy the same place. Belief in a supernatural water-presence belongs to the characters' cultural understanding; the biological behavior of the particular creature is not thereby proved to be under a divine command. Maintaining this distinction makes a rigorous reading of the novel's magical realism possible.

Gajendra-mokṣa and Gaja–Grāha: The Transformation of a Name

After the ancient deliverance narrative is recalled, Burhbā calls the local incident the "Tale of Gaja–Grāha." Naming moves a village episode into a future repertoire of collective stories. The conjunction of gaja (elephant) and grāha (the grasping crocodilian adversary) binds the two aquatic antagonists into a memorable expression. The story relates a Sanskrit-derived designation to the regional gohi, but any claim that the two terms

are exact biological synonyms throughout historical usage would require separate research. The creation of a name functions successfully inside the novel; external linguistic taxonomy remains another question.

The Grammatical Ambiguity of "Gaja–Grāhaka"

The title can be encountered as a compound associated with the elephant and the grāha, while its form also echoes the modern word grāhaka, "customer." Because the story concerns one creature holding another, the classical elephant–crocodile relation gives the relevant context. The spelling of the title alone, however, is not a proof of a historical etymology. Its sound pattern aids remembrance within an oral story. Analysis should emphasize the symbolic origin of the name in the narrative without making uncertain claims about external linguistic history.

Rights over Water and Human Interest: The Missing Ethical Debate

The villagers say that the elephant is theirs and the water belongs to the being they address. They do not demand the destruction of the gohi; they ask that the trapped animal be released. This suggests the possibility of coexistence and of competing claims upon a shared environment. Yet the chapter provides no independent argument about the creature's feeding, territorial behavior, human use of the water source, or the environmental effects of maintaining a temple elephant. The collective prayer offers ethical reconciliation in language, not a developed ecology of rights. For environmental criticism this is a productive unanswered question, not a textual demonstration of wrongdoing.

"Every Crocodile" in the Opening Song: The Limits of Universal Deliverance

The song's final verse suggests the universal maxim that one who preserves or calls a name will escape "every gohi." The prose records only one particular rescue, and even that involves physical effort alongside the invocation. It cannot establish that calling a name, by itself, will guarantee release from the grasp of every crocodilian creature. The difference is between the song's consolatory exaggeration and the limited events demonstrably narrated. As literature, the song turns a particular crisis into a generalized expression of spiritual hope. As a universal inference subjected to Navya-Nyāya scrutiny, the asserted invariable relation remains unproved.

The *Gohi* "Understanding" in Magical Realism: Attributing Human Feelings

The gohi ultimately withdraws into the water without being destroyed. The narrator compares this withdrawal to a recognition that the conflict did not concern it. The figure keeps the story from ending in the annihilation of an enemy. But the creature is not shown expressing peace, compassion, a sense of defeat, or reflective thought in any independently accessible way. Giving a nonhuman being an image of understanding is an artistic technique within magical realism. Treating that image as literal biological evidence would confuse types of discourse. Both the episode's animal-ethical aesthetic and the requirements of evidentiary discrimination can therefore be preserved.

Narrative Pace: Crisis, Prayer, Effort, Rescue, and Ritual

The prose follows five recognizable movements: Gajarāj goes down to drink on a hot afternoon; the gohi seizes his leg and the crowd becomes frightened; the scholar recalls the Purāṇa and Burhbā gives counsel; the youths undertake the physical rescue; and the villagers perform the promised offering at night while Burhbā publicly interprets what happened. The initial crisis unfolds rapidly, the duration of rescue is unspecified, and the conclusion becomes explicitly interpretive. The emotional center shifts from immediate danger to collective resolution. But the story ends before it explores Gajarāj's subsequent life, the mahout's renewed care, or the gohi's own continued existence. Rescue becomes the stopping point for a public moral lesson.

Focalization: The Human Group and the Distance from Nonhuman Life

The narrator displays Gajarāj's bodily danger but does not enter the elephant's consciousness. Burhbā's alleged prior knowledge through his presence in water adds a supernatural perspective. The scholar interprets the event through the Purāṇic example, Sūryanāth organizes assistance, and the youths perform physical work. Human interpreters speak from several positions, while the elephant's and the gohi's inner experiences remain matters of inference. The prose does not endow the animals with human vocabulary. It is therefore a category error to treat the song's suggestion of "calling a name" as a demonstrated instance of an elephant speaking religious words in the main narrative.

The Movement of *Rasa*: Fear, Compassion, Valor, and Relief

The disturbed water, the elephant's cries, and the mahout's frightened appeal generate fear. The vulnerability of a trapped animal elicits karuṇa,

compassion. The patient work of the youths introduces enthusiasm and vīra, the heroic mood; the release of the elephant and the retreat of the gohi bring a moment of tranquility and relief. These moods arise from the narrated succession rather than being arbitrary labels imposed from a plan. Because the opening song already hints at deliverance, the reader experiences less uncertainty about the ultimate outcome and more expectation shaped by compassion and courage.

Dhvani and Symbol: From the Grip on a Leg to the Mind's Bondage

Burhbā's final words extend the idea of release from a literal physical grip in the water to release from the "grip" upon the mind. The metaphor can be read as anticipating later parts of the trilogy concerned with digital or psychological forms of confinement. Yet an elephant's leg physically seized by an animal and a human being's mental bondage do not have the same causes. Their analogous quality lies in helplessness and the possible need for help. No single treatment for every psychological problem follows from that similarity. Recognizing the limit strengthens the symbol rather than diminishing its literary reach.

Foreshadowing the Modern Part: Different Narrative Levels

A parenthetical note at the beginning signals that the phrase "Gaja–Grāha" will appear again in a later part. The closing paratext links it to an "inner Gaja–Grāha" of digital and mental confinement. These are explicit forward-looking remarks about the design of the trilogy, not knowledge possessed by Sūryanāth and the villagers during the episode. The narrator's view of the future must be distinguished from the characters' experience of the present. In this way the prehistory creates a symbolic vocabulary for the larger work, without turning as-yet-unnarrated modern incidents into events within this chapter.

The Mention of the Bhāgavata Purāṇa: Limits of Intertextual Evidence

The author's following commentary names the Gajendra-mokṣa narrative of the Bhāgavata Purāṇa. Within the prose, the old scholar recounts a Purāṇic episode without providing the Sanskrit original or a specific verse. Critical testing therefore involves two distinct tasks: first, identifying how the novel retells the tradition; second, comparing that retelling with an authenticated external Sanskrit text. This review performs the first task. Without a separate comparison, it does not present the scholar's "thousands of years" or the sequence of divine intervention as verified quotations from scripture.

The Social-Historical Question: Who Are the Heroes of the Rescue?

The story assigns different functions: Sūryanāth organizes; the scholar interprets; Burhbā advises; the youths carry out the rescue; the mahout first announces the danger. In Burhbā's final explanation the credit expands to a collective "all of you." This recognition of communal responsibility is valuable, but the individual workers remain unnamed. A Videha Parallel History reading examines the relative authority of scriptural speech, occupational practice, and local knowledge of aquatic life. Labor appears as an action, but the biographies and voices of those who undertake it receive little room.

Women's Participation: Clear in Prayer, Limited in Deliberation

The original explicitly includes women and men in the shared prayers. It does not give a woman a direct speech proposing the technical method of rescue, while its designation "strong young men" identifies those assigned bodily labor. This should not be misread as evidence that women lacked courage or concern; the narrator has distributed different activities among different groups. Sonmā's older water-related practice remains a major background reference, yet the voices of women who might continue that tradition do not appear in the deliberation. The scene therefore does not capture the full plurality of social experience.

A Brief Evidence Register: What Is Certain and What Remains Uncertain

The events established within the prose are these: Gajarāj is a temple elephant; on a hot afternoon he goes to drink from the paired pond; a large gohi seizes his leg; the mahout calls for help; the elderly scholar recalls the Purāṇic story; Sūryanāth runs to Burhbā; villagers pray while young people work with ropes and bamboo; the gohi loosens its grip; Gajarāj reaches the bank alive; the special offering is made at night; and the incident receives the name "The Tale of Gaja–Grāha." Unresolved matters include the reason for the attack, the actual Purāṇic verses recited, the material causal effect of the prayer, the offering's contents, the ontological relationship of the animal to the "Original Gohi," the precise rescue technique, the animals' thoughts, and the origin of Burhbā's supposed presence throughout the water. These distinctions govern the argument of the whole review.

Incongruities of Time, Agency, and the Cause of Release in Song and Prose

Three principal discrepancies recur. First, the song gives the elephant a struggle lasting years, whereas the prose begins on an afternoon and

describes an extended but unmeasured rescue. Second, the song suggests the elephant's own calling of a name, while the prose stages people praying; it does not narrate the elephant uttering religious words. Third, the song can make name-calling itself sound sufficient for deliverance, whereas the prose insists on bodily rescue efforts. The layers may be related as poetry and enacted story, but their differences do not disappear. A critic must not fill the prose's silences with miraculous dialogue that the novel does not contain.

Incongruities of Divine Evidence, Numbers, and Omnipresence

The scholar's embedded myth attributes deliverance to a deity, while the present scene is resolved through human effort and the gohi's release of its grip. The generalized formula that prayer and effort are both necessary has not been demonstrated as a universal causal rule. Statements such as "every person gathered" are conventional expressions of communal inclusiveness, not an actual head count. Burhbā's newly described presence in "every drop of water" expands the earlier rule binding him to the grove, without narrating the intervening change. Some of these differences reflect stylistic compression, others evidentiary gaps, and others additions to a magical ontology. They should not be flattened into a single category of factual error.

Overall Literary Judgment: A Purāṇic Narrative Becomes a Story of Effort

The achievement of "The Tale of the Elephant and the Crocodile" is its attempt to translate an evocative Purāṇic myth into an occasion for practical action in village life. Sūryanāth's organization, the use of ropes and bamboo, the attempt to save the elephant without killing the gohi, and the joining of older verses with local calls develop its social and ecological meaning. The episode does not end by claiming deliverance through prayer alone: it depicts concrete work. At a more exacting level of criticism, significant problems remain—the different time and agency implied by song and prose, the untested causal role of prayer, the ambiguous identity of the "Original Gohi," and Burhbā's unexplained aquatic omnipresence. The assessment is conditionally positive: the ethical inspiration is substantial; the evidentiary structure is mixed; and the autonomous experience of the nonhuman creatures is only sparsely represented.

Verification of Sources, Discipline of Quotation, and the Next Chapter

The primary source is Gajendra Thakur's A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, the complete trilogy, Volume ०, Chapter [–69], "The Tale of

the Elephant and the Crocodile," pages 241–244 according to the table of contents. The opening proverb, "The elephant is in the water, the crocodile is in the water"; the song "Deliverance Through Calling the Name"; the prose account of Gajarāj's peril; the address to the "Original Gohi"; and Burhbā's final speech are read as separate textual layers. The subsequent commentary concerning the Bhāgavata Purāṇa is paratext, not an authenticated direct quotation from scripture without external comparison. The next critical section will examine Chapter [–68], "The Court's First Hearing Date," and the relationships among testimony, judicial procedure, palm-leaf documentation, and communal memory.

Critical Section 33 | Original Chapter −68 — The Court's First Hearing Date

The Prehistory · Formal justice, social time, testimony, institutional delay, and the collective witnessing of waiting

Textual Limits and the Chapter's Organization

"The Court's First Hearing Date" is Chapter [−68] of the prehistory. The original table of contents assigns it page 245 as its opening and page 249 to the following chapter, [−67]; hence pages 245–248 form an index-derived page range, not individually verified page references for each quotation in the electronic text. The chapter is divided into an introductory proverb, the folk song "Justice on a Leaf," a prose account centering on Bholā, Kamalinī, and Burhbā, and an authorial commentary on delayed justice. These textual layers must be distinguished. The present criticism examines the arrival of judicial institutions, the promise of equal rights, the experience of procedural delay, the social cost of waiting, and the new ethical territory brought within the community's practice of remembrance.

The prior figures are not fresh calculations undertaken for this review. In the story Kamalinī pledges assistance, advice, and companionship to those awaiting judgment, but the formal organization of that pledge, or detailed scenes showing repeated meetings, are absent. What a plan might call a new ritual should therefore be examined as an initial commitment to social responsibility rather than narrated as an already accomplished institutional history.

The "First Date" of the Title and the Story's Five Years

Although the title refers to the first court date, the prose is not confined to a single day in court. It encompasses the establishment of a state court, the community's initial welcome, the gradual emergence of delays, Bholā's three years of waiting, his exchange with an elderly lawyer, and a judgment after five years. The "first date" thus becomes the point of entry into a recurring procedure rather than the temporal limit of the story. A small formal stage in adjudication becomes an emblem of a life consumed over a long period. Reading the title merely as the record of a first hearing would obscure both the temporal structure and the moral center of the narrative.

"Dates" and "Leaves" in the Proverb: Two Archival Orders

The opening proverb sets "date after date" against "justice upon a leaf": the court questions the body while the village keeps the name. A hearing date

is the recurring unit of official procedure; the leaf belongs to a more flexible, local record of memory; and body and name designate different dimensions of social existence. Yet no specific statement about Bholā's land dispute, written on a coconut leaf, is submitted to the court in the prose. "Justice upon a leaf" is therefore principally the folk voice's ethical comparison of institutions, not evidence that the actual judgment was written on such a leaf. Its critical sharpness becomes clearer once that distinction is preserved.

The Organization of the Folk Song "Justice on a Leaf"

The folk tune, identified as a kachahari or courthouse song, brings together the distant official's court, heavy papers, repeatedly postponed dates, the constricted breathing of the poor, and the counterimage of testimony beneath the peepal. Its first stanza establishes the distance of official authority; the second, the economic exhaustion produced by procedure; the third, a contrast between written and oral evidence; and the fourth, a pledge that names will endure across generations. The song is thus more than ornament: it offers a moral critique of the court's paperwork from the standpoint of the village's practice of remembering. Its folk-ethical tone, however, does not establish that every written judicial procedure is corrupt or false.

The Song's "Changed Papers": No Documentary Forgery in the Prose

The song includes a line about papers being changed and stamped. The account of Bholā's claim, however, contains no incident involving a forged document, manipulation of written evidence, bribery, fraud with a court seal, or malicious conduct by a judge. Consequently, the song's altered papers must not be treated as confirmed documentary fraud in this particular case. The lyric communicates a general distrust of procedure; the prose dramatizes a more specific structural injustice—delay. These are allegations with different evidentiary weights. Criticism must not automatically convert an expression of popular feeling into a factual accusation against the court in the story.

"The One Who Saw Spoke": The Missing Examination of Witnesses

The folk song imagines people who directly saw an event speaking publicly under the peepal. The prosecution or litigation of Bholā's dispute, by contrast, does not tell us which neighbor witnessed the damaged field, which document was produced, whose evidence the court admitted, or what cross-examination took place. The song celebrates the moral superiority of local witnessing, but the prose never stages a concrete confrontation between rival bodies of evidence. The critic's task is to

identify the missing judicial procedure, not to invent courtroom testimony that the narrative does not contain.

"Our Own Justice" Beneath the Peepal: Limits of the Memory Assembly

The song suggests that the village possesses its own justice under the peepal, whereas the prose identifies the new court as the successor to Ācārya Keśav's old informal assembly for settling disputes. The rite of preserving names beneath the peepal and the procedural rules of an older judicial gathering are not necessarily the same institution. The folk song blends these experiences into a single imagined moral center. Can direct recollection alone replace enforceable judgments, equal legal rights, and a fair opportunity for opposing parties to be heard? The prose provides no systematic answer. Its evocation of communal moral authority does not establish a complete institutional substitute for formal adjudication.

Kamalinī, Sūryanāth's Daughter: A Female Line of Succession

The main narrative says that the responsibility for the ritual passed after Sūryanāth to his daughter Kamalinī. Vimalā, Sūryanāth, and Kamalinī constitute a familial sequence associated with the public institution of memory. Once again a woman identifies a new social problem. The text does not explain Kamalinī's election, formal authorization, professional life, or the participation of other women in the village. Nor does "after Sūryanāth" independently establish the date or fact of his death or any administrative appointment. Within these limits, Kamalinī emerges as an active and accountable figure who subjects a social institution to criticism.

The New State System: A Permanent Building and Written Law

The new court arrives with a masonry building, an appointed judge, and written laws and rules. These three elements create the visible form of institutional modernization: permanent architecture, a designated official, and codified norms. The arrangement replaces the old informal judicial assembly associated with Ācārya Keśav. Yet the narrative identifies no historical state, constitutional stage, territorial jurisdiction, individual judge, or named code of procedure. The presence of a masonry court building alone cannot therefore date the events to a particular colonial or post-independence legal regime in external history.

The Attraction of Equal Rights: A Genuine Departure from the Old Order

Initially the villagers welcome the formal court because, "in principle," its written laws grant equal rights to persons of all castes. The qualification matters. The narrator affirms the possibility of equality at the level of

declared rights; he does not prove that equal access to justice has been achieved in practice. Equally, it would distort the story to condemn the new court as wholly harmful, since it expressly acknowledges the value of formal equality. Nor does the comparative speed of older local practices imply that every caste distinction within those practices was just. The text establishes one difference in timing while leaving a full comparison of fairness, appeals, and enforceable rights unresolved.

Ācārya Keśav's Old Assembly: The Idealization of Memory

The account says that an ordinary land dispute could be "heard in a single day" in the old debating or dispute-settlement assembly. Hearing a complaint in one day is different from completing an impartial examination of evidence, reaching a judgment, and enforcing it within that time. The story offers no comparative archive of the outcomes of the old institution. We should therefore resist transforming it into an immaculate ideal merely because the new court proves slow. The contrast in time is explicit; the respective merits of substantive justice, caste equality, and appellate safeguards remain matters for separate scrutiny.

Filing a Case Is Easy, Obtaining Judgment Difficult: Access versus Outcome

The narrator gives the new system two characteristics: filing a case is relatively easy, but arriving at a decision is slow. This distinction separates formal access to a right from its effective enjoyment. Registration takes an injured claimant through the state's doorway; it does not deliver a decision. For a poor farmer, reaching that door cannot be the sole measure of success. Timely compensation for an actual loss may be far more consequential. The gap between admission into a legal process and the meaningful outcome of that process furnishes the chapter's central institutional critique.

Bholā's Introduction: A Name, Poverty, and a Neighbor's Dispute

Bholā is a poor cultivator and Kamalinī's neighbor. A neighbor's animals damage his field, and he seeks compensation in court. His economic position is central: the damage is likely to affect the livelihood sustained by agricultural work. But the story provides neither the crop, acreage, species of animal, amount of money lost, boundary document, nor name of the defendant. We possess the narrated fact of the dispute and its moral significance, not the documents required to reconstruct an actual legal file. The critic must not supply an invented property history to fill out this briefly introduced poor character.

The Claim for Compensation: An Appeal to Law and Disrupted Livelihood

By seeking compensation Bholā asks for a public remedy rather than pursuing private retaliation. Entering the official legal system initially signals trust in its promise. As the time taken to secure relief expands, however, the day-to-day burden of waiting becomes more prominent than the original damage itself. Journeys to court consume working days that the farmer cannot easily replace. Because farming is tied to seasonal opportunities, the cost of legal access consists not only of possible fees but also of labor withdrawn from the field. The text states this loss of time; it does not specify the cost of travel, bribes, or court charges.

Three Years: The First Explicit Measure of the Case's Stagnation

"Three years had passed," the story says, and Bholā still awaited the next hearing date. The elapsed period is explicit, but the number of hearings, documents filed, and reasons for every adjournment remain unstated. The narrator offers the general explanation that some technical reason arose each time. The abridgment makes procedure appear as a recurring obstacle rather than a set of distinct, examinable incidents. What matters is the pressure of those three years upon a human life, not an imaginary total of court appearances.

Judgment after Five Years: Victory in Law, Damage in Life

The final account states that Bholā receives a favorable decision after five years. By then the field has been ruined for years and his children have grown up hungry. His legal claim has been recognized at the level of judgment, but its value in the course of his life has diminished. The amount awarded, whether payment was ever received, and what order was made against the defendant are not specified. It would therefore be incorrect to write that Bholā actually received compensation in cash after five years. The story's moral irony lies in the split between a victorious judgment and the practical benefit of justice.

Bholā's Children: Invisible Participants in the Litigation

The statement that Bholā's children "grew up hungry" extends the effects of judicial delay beyond the plaintiff to an intergenerational question of nourishment. Their names, genders, ages, health, schooling, mother, and other supportive relationships are not specified. The reviewer must not invent detailed inner lives for children whom the text leaves unrepresented. The brief statement is nonetheless deeply affecting. By the time the court delivers judgment, childhood has passed and cannot be

restored. Human time thus becomes a biological and familial history unlike the court's schedule of hearings.

Lost Working Days: A Distinct Burden upon a Poor Litigant

At every hearing Bholā journeys to the court, loses a day of work, and comes home without a decision. Travel, waiting, and loss of labor are repeated acts whose effect falls unequally across social classes. The text does not establish whether a wealthy claimant might send a representative instead, but it makes the cost of the poor farmer's days a visible moral factor. Repeated adjournment ceases to be an abstract administrative process; it becomes an appropriation of the working body's time. No monetary estimate of the accumulated loss is available, although the narrative evidence of wasted time is clear.

Kamalinī's Initial Diagnosis: Equality and Delay Acknowledged Together

Kamalinī tells Burhbā that the new court is good because it recognizes everyone as equal, but that an injustice of hearing dates is taking shape within it. The distinctive strength of her position is its capacity for two-sided criticism. She neither denies the institution's positive achievement nor conceals the damage produced by its operation. Her awareness of law appears as reasoning, not merely as lamentation. She is neither Bholā's formally appointed advocate nor a judge; her involvement begins in the realm of communal moral deliberation.

Sukhdev Mahto and the Water Clock: An Earlier Disaster Recalled

Burhbā recalls Sukhdev Mahto's case, in which the order determined by a time-measuring instrument deprived him of his turn before he died. This memory places the new court's scheduling practice within a longer sequence of temporal injustice. The modern court and the older procedural device are not identical institutions; what joins them is the experience of losing one's opportunity through enforced waiting. The present chapter does not reconstruct the earlier instrument's precise operation or every circumstance of Sukhdev's death. Those details should not be supplied without examining the prior chapter separately.

"Time, Not an Instrument of Justice, but Its Obstacle": Burhbā's Insight

The double character of time is at the center of Burhbā's observation. An orderly sequence can provide fairness in hearing different people, yet excessive delay can render the right itself useless. He does not thereby deliver an unrestricted doctrine about every administrative procedure; his judgment emerges from the specific judicial situation depicted. Sukhdev's

timekeeping device and Bholā's hearing dates are different instruments by which institutions organize human opportunities. In both, Burhbā recognizes an indifference to the lived time of persons. The custodian of memory, once chiefly a witness to death, becomes a critic of the social consequences of judicial waiting.

The Old Lawyer's Voice: Criticism from Within the Institution

Bholā sits exhausted on the court's veranda. An elderly lawyer beside him, who has watched the courthouse for many years, speaks with a kind of bitter humor about the appetite of hearing dates. The song's accusation from outside the institution now acquires the form of criticism arising within it. The lawyer belongs to the judicial world, yet his experience raises a severe question about its legitimacy. The account does not give his name, office, formal relationship to Bholā's case, or any particular order of the court. He is a literary figure of experienced institutional witnessing, not the source of an authenticated sworn record.

The Veranda: A Visual Center of Exhaustion

Instead of extensively depicting the judge's chamber, the narrative presents the exhausted Bholā on the courthouse veranda. The veranda is a threshold: the petitioner sits outside the place of decision, waiting for judgment. Rather than rehearsing legal doctrine, the writer makes delay perceptible through an embodied situation. The distance between the public promise of rights and the claimant's actual experience becomes visible within the building itself. The story gives only limited architectural detail, no reliable count of the people waiting, and no diagnosis of Bholā's physical condition; such descriptions should not be embellished.

“The Hunger of Hearing Dates”: Constructing a Metaphor

The lawyer says that the court has a kind of hunger called a hearing date. It is a hunger made of paper, but it consumes human time, patience, and sometimes an entire life. The metaphor extends the novel's imagery from a crocodile consuming a living body to an institution consuming years. Judicial adjournment becomes, imaginatively, an invisible creature that devours. The lawyer does not literally encounter a supernatural being in court. The metaphor gradually prepares the later designation of a “ghost of the court,” a phrase for which Burhbā's subsequent interpretation supplies the seed.

“The Ghost of the Court”: An Institutional Metaphor, Not an Apparition

Having heard Bholā's predicament, Burhbā suggests that the new system is producing a sort of ghost, born not of one person's wrongdoing but of the

sluggishness of an entire arrangement. No ghost appears physically in the courtroom or courthouse in this chapter; there is no spectral voice, body, or miraculous attack. The phrase is an interpretive anticipation of a motif the narrator suggests will develop in later sections. To include an actual ghost sighting in the present event register would falsify the narrative. What is being born here is the figurative personification of structural delay.

From One Culprit to the "Entire System": Enlarging Causation

Burhbā explicitly attributes the new injustice to the system's slowness rather than the isolated wrongdoing of one person. The passage moves beyond personal blame toward structural criticism. It does not say that the judge took a bribe, the lawyer deliberately engineered adjournments, or the opposing party maliciously obstructed proceedings. Individual responsibility remains conceptually possible, but the story supplies no specific action by which to assign it. The identification of systemic delay is therefore an important critical achievement; the precise means of institutional reform remain outside the chapter's account.

State Authority and the Village's Ethical Life

The masonry building, the judge, and codified rules embody the state's formal authority. Kamalinī and Burhbā respond to the sufferings of those who wait with a different, communal obligation. The novel does not simply replace one with the other. Kamalinī acknowledges that changing the court's system is beyond her power; she pledges to assist, advise, and accompany the affected people. Community support does not displace the court's legal jurisdiction. It attempts to provide human solidarity where legal access imposes burdens. Such solidarity may be valuable, but no change to the law or judicial administration has actually been achieved in the narrated events.

Kamalinī's Recognition of Limits: "I Cannot Change It"

Kamalinī does not claim the authority to alter the state's rules at will. When she says, "I cannot change the court's system," she recognizes her actual institutional position. This admission makes her proposal credible rather than turning her into an omnipotent reformer. Within the remaining space for action, she undertakes to provide help, advice, and company to people awaiting judgment. The two levels of reform are distinct: structural transformation of the system and immediate support for those harmed by it. The latter does not completely substitute for the former, however urgently it may be needed.

"Help, Advice, and Company": Three Forms of Responsibility

Kamalinī's pledge has three elements. Help suggests practical or material assistance; advice opens the possibility of sharing knowledge; company addresses the loneliness and emotional cost of prolonged waiting. Yet the story does not show the pledge being implemented through specific subsequent actions—money for Bholā, documents prepared for his case, legal representation, meals, or accompaniment to a hearing. These are possible interpretations of the three terms, not documented entries in an enacted programme. The pledge is a seed of an alternative social practice, not detailed evidence of its results.

The Narrator's Certainty: A Pledge Followed by Judgment after Five Years

Kamalinī undertakes to help people, and the chapter ends with Bholā receiving a favorable decision after five years. Nowhere does the text say that her undertaking caused the court to reach its judgment. Nor are the family's hunger and the damage to the field said to have been undone in the interim. The sequence in which a commitment and a judgment are narrated does not establish causation. Communal solidarity may have value without the story measuring its precise effect. Preserving this distinction allows both the hopeful ethical initiative and the tragic final cost to remain intelligible.

Five Years of Waiting: A New Object for Memory

Burhbā's promise to remember Bholā "and his five years of waiting" is the chapter's decisive turn. The preservation of names had extended from the dead and their neglected stories to festivals, relationships, and the suffering of living creatures. Now the years lost by a living litigant themselves become worthy of historical testimony. Irrecoverable time is admitted into the ethical archive of social justice. The result—Bholā won—is not sufficient to describe the event; knowledge of the life spent waiting is necessary to evaluate it.

From Witnessing Death to Witnessing Waiting: Burhbā's Change

Burhbā announces that he will witness not only death but also waiting. The supernatural guardian of memory becomes more than the custodian of posthumous names: he is now an historian of the erosion inflicted upon living people by institutions. This enlargement matters to the novel's wider understanding of evidence, since suffering is not always measured by sudden death; years of opportunity may be taken from a life. Remembering those years, however, is different from compelling a court

to deliver a judgment. The story grants Burhbā the first capacity, not the second.

The Future "Ghost of the Court": Paratext and Present Limits

The opening parenthetical narrative material and the closing authorial note foreshadow the later elaboration of the "ghost of the court." Such knowledge of what will come must not be attributed to Bholā, Kamalinī, or the old lawyer at the time of these events. In the prose's present, the ghost arises as a figurative description of institutional appetite. Its possible transformation in later sections needs separate textual study. Foreshadowing broadens the meaning of this chapter; it does not authenticate scenes that have not yet occurred.

Narrative Time and Event Time: The Recurrence of Adjournment

The institution's founding and the gradual emergence of its difficulties are summarized with great economy; Bholā's first three years of waiting occupy only a few sentences; the lawyer's speech on the veranda forms a close scene; and the final judgment after five years is again compressed into a brief account. The narrator encompasses a long duration in comparatively few words, while retaining the emotional weight of repetition through sequences such as "the first date, the second, the third." No separate hearing is dramatized for each adjournment. An iterative formula stands for many experiences, creating a collision between the duration endured by the body and the brevity of the telling.

Distribution of Dramatic Scenes: Peepal and Veranda

Two principal conversational settings organize the story: Kamalinī's exchange with Burhbā by the peepal and Bholā's conversation with the old lawyer on the courthouse veranda. The first offers a long historical perspective from the ethics of collective memory; the second gives voice to exhaustion from inside the judicial institution. Their alternation makes formal legal procedure and communal responsibility reflect one another. With no speech by the judge, the court remains an institutional system rather than a readily identifiable individual. This intensifies the narrative's structural abstraction but excludes the diversity of reasoning that might occur within legal proceedings.

Focalization: The Characters' Concerns and the Narrator's Knowledge of Time

Kamalinī recognizes the court's social contradiction through what she knows of the village; Bholā experiences the exhaustion of waiting; the elderly lawyer constructs the image of the consuming institution; Burhbā recalls Sukhdev and identifies a pattern extending across generations. The

narrator then supplies a longer view, including the five-year judgment and the children's hunger. No single character witnesses every dimension. The prose places comprehensive temporal knowledge above their partial perspectives. The views of the opposing neighbor, the judge, and the children themselves do not become independent voices.

The Judge's Namelessness and the Impersonality of the Institution

An appointed judge presides in the new court, yet the reader receives neither his name nor his speech, examination of witnesses, detailed judgment, or reasoning. A favorable decision for Bholā is announced after five years without specifying the ground on which it was reached. The institution is consequently represented as an impersonal process, a choice that corresponds to Burhbā's account of the slowness of the entire system. It also restricts the novel's ability to examine the judicial decision's evidentiary or legal complexity. The grounds for the eventual victory remain untested within the narrative.

The Defendant Neighbor's Silence: An Incomplete Adversarial Structure

The narrator says that the neighbor's animals devastated Bholā's field. The neighbor himself never speaks: we do not learn whether he admitted or disputed the damage, nor how his side of the dispute was heard. This silence reinforces sympathy with Bholā while reducing the portrayal of the matter's adversarial structure. The critic must not label the neighbor a fully proved criminal or an innocent victim beyond the terms of the story. Without his response, the chapter centers upon the effects of lost time rather than the adjudication of competing evidence.

Pakṣa, Sādhya, and the Incomplete Chain of Hetu in Navya-Nyāya

A possible pakṣa, or subject of inference, is the delayed procedure of the new court; the sādhya, or property to be established, is the injustice experienced as a result; and the hetu, or grounds, are Bholā's lost working days, damaged cultivation, and hungry children. In this particular account, prolonged judgment and loss of life opportunities are intimately connected. Yet the text does not establish a universal vyāpti that all judicial delay always arises from the same factors or has the same consequences. The farmer's particular circumstances, the court's rules, and technical adjournments remain conditioning elements. These technical categories can clarify the review, but the characters do not themselves deliver a fully articulated Navya-Nyāya disputation.

Perception, Verbal Testimony, and Inference: Evidence in Bholā's Case

The narrator reports the damage to Bholā's field, on the basis of which Bholā approaches the court. The precise means by which Kamalinī learns of every adjournment are not fully explained. The lawyer's account of institutional practice is experiential verbal testimony, while Burhbā's "ghost" is a moral inference and metaphor. The story does not show which firsthand witness, document, pleading, or answer from the defendant proved decisive in court. Epistemological categories can distinguish these forms of knowledge, but they cannot authorize an invented sequence of evidentiary examination in the lawsuit.

Time Is Not a Thing: The Expenditure of a Right

The years Bholā spends in court cannot be returned to him. Opportunities to cultivate, feed his children, and earn by his labor have already been lost. The court eventually accepts the legal claim, but the narrative does not establish whether the elapsed years were compensated. Burhbā can preserve the memory of time spent waiting; he cannot thereby recover the missing harvests. This distinction proposes a subtler criterion for the effectiveness of justice: was relief delivered quickly enough to remain useful in the life that required it? The story raises the question through concrete loss, not through a detailed statistical account.

"Justice Delayed": Distinguishing Paratext from Story

The authorial commentary after the chapter links the episode to the familiar maxim "justice delayed is justice denied." The phrase functions here as modern interpretive paratext. No character in the courtroom formally invokes the English legal maxim in the prose narrative. Bholā's experience makes its moral implications vivid, but the story does not thereby identify a particular jurisdiction, statutory rule, or historical judicial decision. Claims about external legal history would require separate primary sources. The immediate basis for this review remains the narrated five-year delay and its familial cost.

Indian Rasa Theory: Karuṇa and Moral Indignation

Bholā's exhaustion, his wasted working days, the damage to the field, and his children's hunger are concrete determinants of karuṇa, the experience of pathos. The elderly lawyer's light laughter sharpens the scene through bitter irony. Burhbā's fear and silence enlarge compassion into a question of collective morality. The eventual favorable judgment does not generate an uncomplicated happy ending, since the damage to life has already occurred. The emotional movement therefore settles in grief mixed with

indignation, not complete repose. Kamalinī's pledge directs compassion from passive lament toward active solidarity, while leaving Bholā's losses intact.

A Dhvani-Centered Reading: The Migration of "Hunger"

In the previous chapter a crocodile physically held an elephant in the pond. Here the lawyer imagines an institution with an appetite made of paper, consuming the time of human beings. An expression associated with animal predation migrates into the domain of administrative harm. It returns to a literal, bodily meaning when Bholā's children are described as growing up hungry. The "hunger" of paperwork confronts the hunger of children, producing a concentrated poetic irony. Symbolic kinship does not, however, establish that the mechanical causes of the two kinds of injury are identical.

The Recurrence of Information and the Refrain of the Song

"Date after date" recurs in the song. The narrator enumerates successive dates, the old lawyer describes the longevity of the court's appetite, and Burhbā promises to remember five years of waiting. These repetitions give the reader an experience of duration through language. But every repeated phrase is not a new event: much of the chapter represents the same process through varied emotional registers. Narratological analysis of frequency must distinguish the reporting of one occurrence from an utterance standing for indefinitely many similar occurrences. The song intensifies the experience without adding new judicial facts.

From Ācārya Keśav to the State Court: The Ambivalence of Social Change

The old informal assembly stands for local promptness, while the newly written legal system promises formally equal rights. The novel does not offer a simple rejection of modernization: the court is initially welcomed, only later becoming the source of injury for a particular claimant. The contradiction of legal change is that universality of rights and practical effectiveness do not necessarily grow together. The story successfully establishes a problem, even though it does not present the data needed for a comprehensive administrative history comparing two systems.

Videha Parallel History: Recording the Poor Person's Waiting

Official court records may value case numbers, hearing dates, and final orders. From the perspective of the village's guardian of memory, what matters is that a poor cultivator named Bholā lost five years of his life. Videha Parallel History therefore asks that the social record of experience stand alongside the institutional register of decisions. No actual case

number, filed document, court record, or certified transcript appears here; this is a literary study, not the archival reconstruction of an actual lawsuit. The chapter's value lies in giving a voice to an experience that a favorable final order might otherwise conceal.

Bholā's Singular Story and the Many Who Wait

Kamalinī refers to numerous people like Bholā who suffer from repeated hearing dates, but the novel develops only Bholā as a particular example. Moving from one character to a shared problem is a familiar literary strategy, grounded here in the concrete loss of labor. The "many" are not counted or differentiated by caste, sex, homelessness, disability, or particular legal circumstances. The story is consequently a representation of structural risk rather than an empirical survey of all groups affected by delay.

The Future of a Woman's Pledge: What Institution-Building Would Require

Kamalinī's commitment could become the beginning of social change. For a recognizable institution to develop, however, the practice would need repetition, collaborators, resources, and some form of public recognition. None is described in detail in the present chapter. It is therefore unsupported to claim that Kamalinī has already established a functioning legal-aid institution. The absence should be recorded as an analytical finding, not filled with imagined volunteers or meetings.

Possible Reform: Separating Textual Facts from Critical Questions

Readers may legitimately ask how the number of adjournments might be reduced, how poor claimants' lost working days might be compensated, or how local testimony could be given lawful evidentiary effect. These are research and policy questions provoked by the novel, not actions the novel depicts. The chapter offers no complete schedule of legal reforms or technical plan for court administration. Criticism must retain a visible boundary between events supported by the text, the author's suggested meanings, and questions proposed by the reviewer. Only then can its literary merit be assessed without unsupported claims about legal policy.

Three Worlds of Time: Court, Life, and Memory

The court measures time in hearing dates; Bholā measures it in crops, children's hunger, and working days; Burhbā measures it by the preservation of names across generations. These three clocks assign different meanings to the same span. Judgment arrives after five years, but what Bholā has lost during those years cannot be restored. Burhbā turns that loss into an object of long-term memory. The threefold temporal

structure makes formal victory and experienced damage opposite outcomes of a single event. The narrative refuses to reduce this contradiction to an unfortunate episode in one person's life.

Restraint in Magical Realism: The "Ghost" Is Still a Word

The previous chapter presented Burhbā's supernatural claim to be present throughout water. In this chapter the phrase "ghost of the court" names an imagined form of institutional violence, but no embodied apparition is portrayed. The symbolism personifies social procedure without staging a meeting with a literal ghost inside the courthouse. Whatever the foreshadowed future sections may do with the figure, the evidentiary limit here is the metaphor of waiting and hunger. Treating every supernatural-sounding name as an event already enacted would confuse distinct narrative levels.

Overall Critical Judgment: Life Lost before Justice Arrives

The chapter's decisive achievement is its movement from the welcome given to formally caste-neutral written law toward a poor cultivator's irrecoverable loss of time. Kamalinī's balanced criticism, the old lawyer's "hunger for dates," Burhbā's memory of Sukhdev, and Bholā's victory only after five years give this movement force. Its limitations are equally clear: we do not see the actual hearing, the opposing case, the documentary evidence, the judge's reasoning, or the effect of Kamalinī's proposed support. The changed papers of the song are not verified in the prose; the "ghost" is still a metaphor. Keeping these differences visible enables a serious assessment of both the work's social sensitivity and the economies of its narration.

Source Limits, Significant Terms, and the Next Section

The primary source is Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter [–68], "The Court's First Hearing Date," index-derived pages 245–248. The proverb, the courthouse song "Justice on a Leaf," the account of Bholā's lawsuit, the elderly lawyer's words on the veranda, and Burhbā's final declaration that he witnesses waiting are distinct textual bases. The previously supplied figures are not an independent recount. The case number, judge's name, damages awarded, reasons for individual adjournments, and completed institutional form of Kamalinī's assistance remain unspecified. Chapter [–67], "The Call from Abroad," turns to migration, belonging, the absent person's name, and an ethical comparison between money and relationships.

Critical Section 34 | Original Chapter –67 — The Call from Abroad

The Prehistory · Migration, contracts, the testimony of absence, uncertainty of knowledge, and the communal preservation of names

Textual Extent, Original Form, and Critical Question

The original table of contents places Chapter [–67], "The Call from Abroad," at page 249 and the following chapter, [–66], at page 253. Pages 249–252 are thus its estimated printed extent, not verified line-by-line locations for its quotations. The narrative consists of an opening proverb, a bidesiyā folk song entitled "A Letter from Abroad," prose depicting the arrival of a labor broker and Rāmsevak's departure, and a separate authorial note on the crisis of memory associated with indentured migration. Its principal narratological question is how a village accommodates within its register of names a person who has left, lost contact, and whose status as living or dead cannot be established. Jānakī's new rite provides the ethical response; Burhbā's repeated admission of ignorance defines the limits of its truth claims.

The figures attached to the chapter are preassigned textual indicators, not an independent word recount or conclusive measure of event density. The planning emphasis on history, temporal compression, and generational change needs to be tested against the actual story. In only a few paragraphs the narrative encompasses succession from Kamalinī to Jānakī, a proposed three-year contract, Rāmsevak's absence of indeterminate length, and his mother's waiting "year after year." These timescales, and the distinction between historical contextualization and scenes actually narrated, require special attention.

The "Call" in the Title: An Address without a Reply

The "call" of the title is not simply Rāmsevak speaking from a foreign country. Collective pronunciation of his name and his mother's expectation of an answer are more prominent in the account. Rāmsevak sends no letter, message, or call from abroad. This apparently contrary fact enlarges the title's meaning: the absent person's name is spoken among those who remain, without communication returning from the person addressed. The call must therefore not be mistaken for an accomplished exchange. The absence of reply creates the central emotional tension. The call gives memory an audible local presence; it does not demonstrably overcome geographical separation.

The Proverb's Opposition of Money and Name: A System of Values

The opening lines propose that foreign lands give wealth but take away one's name, while a person remembered by the village is not lost even abroad. This is a folk formulation of a possible conflict between economic advancement and social recognition. "Foreign lands give wealth" is not a guarantee of prosperity: the prose contains no evidence of Rāmsevak's wages, living conditions, or remittances. "They take away one's name" expresses fear of oblivion; it does not show that Rāmsevak has forgotten his village. The proverb's moral design and the particular character's history occupy separate evidentiary levels. Maintaining that distinction enables criticism of an economic temptation without placing an unsupported accusation upon the migrant himself.

The Bidesiyā Tune: A Cultural Tradition within the Song

The chapter's song "A Letter from Abroad" is assigned a bidesiyā folk tune. The choice brings into play migration's sorrow, the ordinary objects of departure, the mother's courtyard, and longing for correspondence. The source, however, identifies no particular historical bidesiyā play, rāga, singer, rhythm, or recorded performance. The cultural association of the name is one thing; a specific historical staging is another. The song intensifies the experience of distance and household memory through vernacular language. It does not independently document every event experienced by the particular characters in this chapter.

Departure at Dawn in the Song, the Mother's Night of Farewell in the Prose

The song's second stanza depicts a son leaving at dawn while his mother stands at the doorway. The prose instead shows Rāmsevak's mother going to the peepal on the "night of departure." There is no unavoidable contradiction: she could have prayed at night and seen her son off the next morning. Yet the prose does not specify such a sequence, nor does it give the precise hour when he set out. Dawn in the song and the farewell night of the prose are therefore distinct temporal indications at different textual levels. A possible reconciliation must not be promoted into an event that definitely took place. The general lyric image and the particular scene of a mother's anxiety serve different purposes.

Letters and Money Orders in the Song, No News of Rāmsevak in the Prose

The folk song describes a migrant sending his name home in a letter and money through a money order. Rāmsevak's situation in the prose is expressly the opposite: no letter, no message, only silence. This distinction

is crucial. The lyric evokes a general or wished-for pattern of remaining in touch; the narrative describes a broken connection. It would contradict the text to claim on the authority of the song that Rāmsevak sent money to his mother, wrote letters, earned wages, or maintained contact. The divergence may also have a poetic effect, exposing the sorrowful gap between cultural reassurance and an individual experience of severed communication.

"Across Seven Seas": Poetic Distance and an Unidentified Destination

"Across seven seas" makes geographical distance immense in the song. The prose tells of a broker's offer of work in a "distant land," but identifies no vessel, port, voyage, country, itinerary, or actual place of employment. The lyric image cannot be converted into a precise claim that Rāmsevak crossed seven seas to a named island. From his mother's standpoint the separation may seem to amount to thousands of miles; this too is an emotional measure rather than cartographic information. Criticism should attend to the rasa of distance without inventing an itinerary for a colonial-era migrant.

From Kamalinī to Jānakī: Cultural Continuity through Women

After Kamalinī, her daughter Jānakī assumes responsibility for the ritual. The sequence extending from Vimalā through Sūryanāth and Kamalinī gives a recurring role to women's leadership in the institution of remembrance. Jānakī does not merely keep the inherited rule intact: she devises a new procedure in response to a question about Burhbā's limited powers. Nevertheless, the phrase "after Kamalinī" does not itself tell us that Kamalinī died, why she gave up the role, or in which year the succession occurred. Female agency appears through definite words and institutional decisions, while the formal mechanisms of selection and wider community participation remain only lightly described.

The Broker's Entrance: Honeyed Speech, Bright Clothes, and Papers

The labor broker is introduced through three material and bodily signs: a sweet tongue, shining clothes, and a bundle of documents. Together they suggest both apparent credibility and possible deception. Persuasive speech awakens economic hopes; clothing displays prosperity; paper confers an appearance of institutional formality. But the narrative gives neither his individual name, his employer, an identifiable organization, documents detailing a particular fraud, nor a separately substantiated criminal act. His presentation arouses suspicion of misleading attraction without providing the full evidence of a specific offense. It would therefore be inappropriate to assign him the identity of a known historical indenture recruiter.

The Three-Year Contract: The Distance between Promise and Document

The broker openly offers a three-year contract, good wages, and a return home after the work is completed. Rāmsevak puts his thumb impression on a paper he cannot fully read. The scene establishes an unequal relation of knowledge between oral promise and written contract. It does not disclose whether the actual document specified three years, what wage it stipulated, or how the return clause was worded. It is therefore unsupported to assert that Rāmsevak had an independently verified legal right to return upon completion of exactly three years. The narrative dramatizes contractual asymmetry; it does not reproduce a complete case file.

The Thumb Impression: Consent and Informed Consent

Rāmsevak affixes his thumb without fully reading the written conditions or having them read to him. Outward completion of an act of agreement is thus distinct from knowledge of what the document actually binds him to. He is attracted to the broker's offer, but the precise implications of the written obligations remain unknown to him. The ethical concept of informed consent is useful for analyzing this imbalance. Nevertheless, the novel does not contain a judicial finding that a particular contract was legally invalid under any specified historical statute. The thumb impression is an event in the narrative; a definite conviction for fraud or a particular legal penalty is not.

Poverty, Land, and Debt: Pressures that Push People to Migrate

Poor families in the village are drawn to the proposal because of insufficient land and mounting debts. Rāmsevak decides to leave when he sees his family's hardship. Migration is consequently not represented simply as the result of uncontrolled personal greed; it is connected to structural constraints upon livelihood. Land scarcity and indebtedness provide the necessary beginnings of a socioeconomic account, but the story names no creditor, exact amount owed, household income, or alternative employment scheme. To blame the migrant merely for desiring money would therefore be an ethical simplification. His choice unfolds within a difficult range of possibilities shaped by poverty.

Rāmsevak, Bholā's Grandson: From Judicial Delay to Migration

The prose calls Rāmsevak "Bholā's grandson." In the immediately preceding chapter, Bholā's land dispute remained unresolved for five years while his field deteriorated and his children grew up hungry. Linking the generations suggests a possible historical passage from judicially aggravated deprivation to a descendant's migration. It does not, however, establish

that Bholā's particular lawsuit was the sole or decisive cause of Rāmsevak's departure. The current story explicitly presents hardship as a motive, but the poverty of different generations cannot be reduced without additional evidence to one lawsuit. The literary trace of inherited distress and a strict claim of causation are distinct.

The Laboring Character's Silence: Rāmsevak's Voice Disappears after the Decision

Rāmsevak accepts the offer and places his thumb on the document. After that, the reader hears no direct speech from him and receives no account of his journey, work, feelings, final wishes, or experience in the foreign country. From the village's perspective, the absent man becomes the center of a mystery, but his own perspective is unavailable. The creative advantage is the sustained uncertainty felt by the mother; the limitation is the absence of the worker's voice on exploitation, resistance, or the new society he may have encountered. Inventing a letter or a death scene to fill the gap would destroy the narrative's carefully preserved ethical uncertainty.

The Mother's Namelessness: The Central Paradox of Preserving Names

Rāmsevak's mother supplies the chapter's principal emotional voice, yet her personal name is not given in the main prose. A novel committed to protecting every person's name identifies its most distressed participant here only by the relational term “mother.” This is not automatically a failure of moral feeling, since the maternal role makes her anxiety widely recognizable. It is nonetheless an important representational omission beside the work's larger pledge that each person deserves a name. The mother in the general song resembles Rāmsevak's mother; it cannot substitute for an independently developed life history of the woman in the story.

The Peepal's Roots on the Night of Farewell: Continuity of Place

On the farewell night Rāmsevak's mother approaches the peepal. Burhbā's long practice of witnessing, the preservation of names through writing, the expansion of the Channā Grove, and the recurrent new-moon ritual have already made this site the village's center of remembrance. Emigration consequently enters a pre-existing public institution rather than remaining the private fear of a single household. The mother asks whether a power rooted in the grove and pond can reach a foreign land. The place therefore marks not only emotional attachment to home but also the functional boundary of the supernatural system of witnessing.

Burhbā's Admission of Ignorance: Ethical Restraint in the Service of Truth

Burhbā admits that he does not know how far his power extends. Later, when the mother asks whether Rāmsevak is living or dead, he again answers unequivocally, "I do not know," adding that he will not lie to her. This repeated recognition of ignorance gives the guardian's claim to memory an ethical reliability. He does not become an invented omniscient authority who assures a grieving woman, without evidence, of either survival or death. The refusal to claim knowledge where no means of knowing is available has the moral quality of epistemic discipline associated with Navya-Nyāya. Within the novel's supernatural order, the scene establishes an uncommon humility.

The Grove and Pond as a Boundary: Renewed Limits upon Supernatural Existence

Chapter [–69] had represented Burhbā as present "in every drop of water." In the present chapter he describes his powers as bound to "this grove, this pond, the memory of this village," and doubts his ability to see at a great distance. Together the statements create an unresolved problem of extent. If "every drop" referred to all water everywhere, uncertainty about distant persons would require an explanation. If it referred only to the local pond, the two descriptions could be reconciled. But the earlier chapter did not articulate that restriction. Criticism may propose it as a possibility, not assert it as an established formal law of magic.

Jānakī's New Practice: Social Ingenuity Compensates for Limited Powers

When Jānakī learns that Burhbā cannot confidently reach faraway lands, she proposes that the village establish a practice to compensate for his inability. Reliance upon supernatural power is reduced as communal initiative increases. Instead of making a new promise of distant miracles, people work with what they possess: names, stones or threads, roots of the peepal, and the periodic observance of the new moon. The rite is a cultural technique for responding to the separation of people and places. It offers a local presence to a distant name; it does not disclose the absent person's actual circumstances abroad.

A Stone or a Thread: The Meaning of a Minimal Material Sign

Jānakī suggests placing "a small stone, or a small thread" at the peepal's roots for each emigrant. The humble objects can act as bearers of memory without the expense of an elaborate memorial. Stone may suggest material endurance and thread fragility, but the original prose establishes no fixed

symbolic rule assigning these meanings to the alternatives. It does not tell us which family selects which object, or whether Rāmsevak's particular token is a stone or thread. The critic must therefore not settle that undecided detail by inventing an object the mother touched.

Every New Moon: Recurrence and Institutional Rhythm

The new rite takes place at the end of the new-moon kabaddi observance. Each person who has gone abroad is named in turn, and the sign left at the roots is touched. Spoken name, material contact, and lunar periodicity combine to give the procedure an institutional shape. During the epidemic the village had instituted a collective calling of names every morning; here it returns to the older rhythm of the new moon for a different social need. This adaptability of time is a notable feature of the memory system. The narrative supplies neither a census of emigrants nor a complete attendance record for every new-moon night.

Naming the Rite "The Call from Abroad": From Private Grief to Social Institution

After Jānakī's proposal, the narrator says expressly that the practice was established and called "The Call from Abroad." The proposal is one stage, establishment a second, and repeated performance on successive new-moon nights a third. Unlike Kamalinī's pledge of help, advice, and companionship in Chapter [–68], the story does describe the institution of this rite and states that it continued to be performed. The distinction matters when comparing what social change is actually depicted across consecutive chapters: a declared intention and a recurrent established practice are not equivalent textual outcomes.

Living, Dead, and Missing: A Third Place in the Social Register

When news of a person's death arrives, the person's token receives special attention. If no information arrives, the token remains for years in a condition "neither fully in the category of the living nor fully in that of the dead." This is not a third biological state; it is a social and archival category of incomplete knowledge. The practice avoids the injustice of declaring a person dead without evidence while refusing to promise survival without proof. Its ethical force lies precisely in the ability to preserve a person through acknowledged uncertainty.

Rāmsevak's Failure to Return: Event versus Unknown Fate

The narrator reports that Rāmsevak "never returned," and that no letter or message arrived. From the village's point of view, absence has no narrated end. Yet "did not return" does not mean "died." Accident, captivity, chosen migration, a new household, illness, or exploitation are

conceivable explanations, but none is established by the text. Nor does the story confirm the point of his journey at which contact was lost. To impose a general example from indentured labor history and then locate Rāmsevak's death in an invented country would violate the source. His unknowable fate is the epistemological and emotional center of the chapter.

The Mother's Year-after-Year Recurrence: A Narrative Rhythm of Waiting

Every new-moon night the mother returns to the peepal, touches the sign, hears her son's name, and goes home again. One sentence can thus contain many years of repeated action. The narrator does not stage each year's change in feeling; "year after year" condenses durable grief. The mother's direct speech returns in a final question: is her son alive or dead? The question is neither proof of death nor an assurance of life. It expresses the suffering of a conclusion indefinitely deferred. The story leaves her question open instead of giving her an invented moment of certainty.

Burhbā's Truthfulness: The Dignity of Uncertainty rather than False Comfort

When questioned, Burhbā says neither that Rāmsevak is certainly alive nor that he is dead. He promises only that the man's name will be remembered. The consolation is incomplete, but it contains no deception. In the novel's wider ethics of witnessing, intellectual honesty becomes a form of compassionate responsibility. A fabricated assurance might bring transient relief, but it would violate the available evidence. The scene's achievement is to present memory not as a claim to know everything but as a public commitment not to forget. The statement's strength comes from its refusal to solve grief falsely, even while declining to abandon the grieving person.

"Distance Cannot Erase a Name": The Limits of Victory

Burhbā's final assertion is that distance cannot wipe out a name; it can only lengthen uncertainty. Local acts of remembrance can protect the name despite the absence of knowledge about the person's actual condition. The victory is therefore strictly limited. Community members will remember Rāmsevak, but they cannot thereby guarantee his physical safety or his reunion with his family. This incomplete ending is sensitive precisely because it acknowledges what remembrance cannot accomplish. Converting the preservation of his name into a declaration that the sufferings of migration have ended would conceal exploitation, disappearance, and the cost of his mother's waiting.

Preserving the Names of the Living: Revising a Death-Centered Theory of Memory

Many earlier rites in the novel protect names, melodies, or memorial trees associated with the dead. The new practice registers migrants even while they may be alive. Memory ceases to be solely an action performed after death and becomes a continuing social relationship with people who are absent. The lack of news is not converted into death, but sustained as a form of open waiting. This marks a significant institutional change in the work's overall ethics of memory. It does not, however, remedy the material hardships of the distant person; symbolic inclusion and physical welfare remain distinct responsibilities.

Social Relationship instead of Geography: Membership and Migration

Jānakī's procedure makes residence within the physical village an insufficient criterion for belonging. Someone living thousands of miles away may remain part of the communal observance because they are remembered as one who left the village. Membership expands from local presence to social relationship. But the text does not specify who maintains the register, what happens to children born abroad, or how people who depart to settle among other communities are included. The innovation is a recognizable initial rule, not a comprehensive constitution for every possible form of migration.

Women's Intellectual Agency: Different Roles for Jānakī and the Mother

The mother poses the immediate question: who can witness her son's name in a distant land? Burhbā admits a limit; Jānakī translates the difficulty into a public practice. The intellectual initiative therefore does not reside exclusively in the male supernatural witness. Private maternal fear becomes a community-wide problem, and Jānakī formulates a rule in response. Yet the mother's own name remains unstated while Jānakī is identified by an authorized position. One woman becomes an institutional designer and the other an emblem of grief. Both retain equal human dignity, but the distribution of speaking and narrative authority is not equal.

The Broker as Class Intermediary: An Agent, Not the Employer

The person who arrives at the village is not identified as the proprietor of the plantation, factory, or other establishment where labor will occur. He is a broker who brings information and contractual papers for distant employment. This role places a mediator between impoverished workers and an employer they cannot directly inspect. Unequal access to

information can give such a mediator disproportionate power. But the story provides no employer's name or record of the broker's payment. Neither a specific criminal identity nor the name of a historical recruiter can responsibly be imposed upon him.

Three Contractual Years against the Mother's Indefinite Waiting

The oral offer promises a bounded term of three years, while Rāmsevak's absence acquires the open-ended quality of "never returned." Their opposition brings together the possibility of deception, broken expectations, and an apparently limitless extension of time. Nothing definite is narrated about the moment when the promised three years expired: there is no verified extension of the contract, confinement, receipt of wages, or attempted return. The mother's indefinite waiting is therefore a continuing future without an answer, not a precisely measured record of his entire lifespan. Narrative time turns a fixed term of employment into unresolved familial suffering.

The Household's Material Life: Debt, Food, and the Distance of Relatives

Rāmsevak takes the risk of migration because of his family's straitened circumstances. Land scarcity and indebtedness are offered as broad pressures upon a class of villagers, but the prose does not describe the household's daily food supply, the mother's means of support, the resources of other relatives, or the cost of the journey. The omission matters because the chapter directs its ethical resolution toward remembering home, while the household's material insecurity remains partly in the background. Readers may perceive a link between the earlier family's judicial hardship and the present family's migration; a conclusive economic history would require more evidence.

The "Money Order" as a Temporal Sign in the Folk Song

The word "money order" in the lyric refers to an institution for transferring money alongside the possibility of correspondence. The prose itself does not name a post office, a postal service, postage, or a geographical date sufficient to identify an external period. Treating the lyric's money-order imagery and the labor broker's contract as exact evidence of one historical date would overstate the text. The juxtaposition may evoke a culturally layered history of migration. But no money order is said to have been sent by Rāmsevak: the term belongs to the folk song, not to a verified transaction in his life.

Historical Indenture: Distinguishing Authorial Paratext from Evidence

The commentary after the chapter refers to the colonial system of indentured labor, mentioning Mauritius, Fiji, the Caribbean, and other destinations. This is the author's comparative framing, not the prose narrative's identification of where Rāmsevak went. A three-year offer, a poorly understood document, and a migrant's disappearance undoubtedly recall histories resembling indenture. They do not establish that this fictional worker reached Mauritius or Fiji, name his ship, or date his departure. Confirmation of such external historical facts would require separately verified sources. The claims of the present criticism remain grounded in the fictional representation.

Future Hong Kong and Digital Fraud: Paratextual Foreshadowing

The concluding commentary also points toward future sections concerning Hong Kong and the digital deception of migrants. None of those later events takes place in the present Jānakī–Rāmsevak story. Forward-looking paratext connects the episode with the extended architecture of the trilogy; it does not supply digital devices, electronic messages, or a specific scam affecting Rāmsevak in the chapter under discussion. The temporal distinction is essential: the present episode turns upon a paper contract, geographical separation, and silence, while the later technological world is a projected site of comparison.

The Bidesiyā Song's Moral Warning and the Pressure Placed upon Migrants

The song suggests that those who earn money and forget their village return as strangers, whereas a person who keeps the name intact finds a home that remembers. The opposition gives value to memory and belonging, yet it may also turn the complicated circumstances of migration into the individual's moral fault of “forgetting the village.” Rāmsevak's silence is no proof of voluntary forgetfulness. He may lack access to communication, or there may be other barriers; the story establishes none of their actual causes. A critic should not condemn the migrant's unexplained silence as betrayal. The general warning of the song must remain distinct from the fate of a missing worker.

Rāmsevak's Invisible Labor: Hope of Work without a Scene of Work

The broker promises “good wages,” while the song imagines the migrant sweating at work in a distant country. The prose never shows Rāmsevak actually laboring at a particular site. There is no description of wage payments, shifts, a field or factory, accommodation, coworkers,

supervision, or resistance. Rather than furnishing a detailed social history of a migrant worker's labor abroad, it concentrates upon his departure and the family's unknowing wait at home. This choice makes the emotional stakes powerful but restricts the material representation of labor in the foreign country.

The Gap in the Journey: Between Departure and Disappearance

The story narrates a thumb impression and a farewell. Its next known fact is that Rāmsevak does not return. Travel, border crossings, arrival, employment, and possible attempts to come home occupy an unrepresented interval. The missing span itself becomes a kind of abyss within the reader's experience. Reason seeks explanations, but the narrator gives no source from which to establish one. To remain faithful to the narrative, criticism must preserve the gap instead of replacing it with a manufactured travelogue. A conjecture about disappearance and an observed event belong to different evidentiary classes.

Maternal Focalization: Waiting Repeated Across Generations

The mother's question on the farewell night concerns an anticipated danger. Her question years later concerns an unresolved status: is her son living or dead? Between these two direct exchanges lie many repeated new-moon observances. The narrative communicates her distress not by issuing a clinical psychological definition but through concrete acts: touching a token, hearing the name, and returning home. Other feelings, anger, efforts to locate news abroad, or conversations with other women are not depicted. Acknowledging those omissions also reveals a limitation of her characterization: much of her life becomes the enduring figure of a waiting mother.

Evidence through Touch: Stone or Thread and the Absent Body

The mother's hand does not touch her son. It touches the memorial sign chosen for him. The act stages a tension between bodily absence and an ongoing social relationship. The token is material, but its connection with a migrant comes from the shared convention Jānakī establishes and the memory sustained by his family. It cannot prove whether the person is alive. The recurrence of touch grounds the story in ordinary human action rather than miraculous receipt of information from abroad. The emotional movement passes from compassion toward a restrained form of composure, without closing the uncertainty.

Life or Death Unresolved: A Navya-Nyāya Problem of Evidence

The absence of news about Rāmsevak is a negative social fact. It is not sufficient evidence for either the inference “he is dead” or its opposite, “he

is alive." The invariable relation between "no message arrived" and "death occurred" has not been shown. Lack of communication, obstruction in transit, and other circumstances remain conceivable counterconditions. Burhbā's admission of ignorance supplies a practical response to this insufficiency. The analytical terms pakṣa, sādhya, hetu, and upādhi may clarify the situation, but Burhbā does not conduct a formally articulated debate in those terms. They belong to the reviewer's method, not to the character's verbatim historical discourse.

The Fallacy of Assigning Blame from the Absence of a Letter

"No letter, no message" is an informational absence. To treat it as proof that Rāmsevak forgot his mother would turn an uncertain cause into a definite state of mind. The alleged inferential relationship lacks vyāpti, since external obstacles to communication are possible. The song warns generally against forgetting one's village, but applying that warning as a factual charge against Rāmsevak would lack support. This distinction safeguards the moral standing of a worker whose fate cannot be investigated from the evidence given. The critic may respect the song's social value while recognizing the danger of applying its generalized judgment to an individual.

The Durability of a Name and the Reproduction of a Record

Leaving a sign at the peepal is a single initial act; speaking the name on every new moon renews it. If the sign were left without recurrent acknowledgment, its social relationship could weaken. The combination of stable object and repeated performance becomes a cultural register. Yet the story does not prescribe the exact form of naming, how to distinguish two migrants with the same name, how newcomers learn the significance of a token, or when a token might be removed. The ideal that names will not vanish depends upon ongoing social transmission of knowledge. The text implies that need without giving a complete manual for fulfilling it.

Letters, Remittances, and the Village's Voice: Three Kinds of Medium

The song imagines letters and money orders; in Rāmsevak's particular history those means of contact fail or are absent; Jānakī's rite relies on oral remembrance at home. Their social functions differ. A letter can communicate news from elsewhere, a remittance can sustain an economic tie, and the ritual calling of a name can relieve some part of the family's isolation. But the call at the peepal is not a technical communications network: it does not tell the village where Rāmsevak is. The new practice is an ethical form of address when communication breaks down, not a functional replacement for receiving information from abroad.

Burhbā's Old Promise and a New Geography

Burhbā's longstanding pledge concerned the preservation of those who died, were forgotten, or suffered injustice within the social world he knew. The present rite admits a possibly living emigrant, while keeping the witness at home and declining to claim knowledge of his distant circumstances. The limits of supernatural geography and the expansion of moral responsibility thus move in different directions: Burhbā cannot say how far he can see, but the community can extend its memory to those beyond its territory. Acknowledging a limit is not a defeat here; it is a precondition for cooperation without a false claim of omniscience.

Narrative Time: Succession in One Sentence, Waiting over Many Years

The chapter introduces the generation after Kamalinī with very few words. The broker's arrival is one scene; the mother's question another; Jānakī's proposal a third; the repeated observance spans years in summary. Rather than recounting the overseas journey, the narrative compresses time to foreground the development of a social institution. Three years belong to the promised contract, an unknown multitude of years to the mother's wait, and a longer sequence to the village's historical memory. These nonidentical measures enable a compact narrative to establish an ethical connection across several generations.

The Ratio of Scene to Summary and Narrative Incompleteness

The broker's announcement supplies the first dramatic episode. The mother's appeal to Burhbā gives the central emotional dialogue, Jānakī's proposal the intellectual action, and the final question about life and death the last intense scene. Almost the whole foreign life is compressed into the assertion that Rāmsevak never returned. The absent portion creates an effective mystery, but it does not represent the full diversity of migrant labor. The review should admit both the artistic power and the limited social scope of the chosen perspective, rather than treat every absence as an inherently successful artistic mystery.

The Center of Karuṇa: Not a Confirmed Death but a Missing Answer

In several preceding chapters, death was narrated as an established event and rites subsequently affirmed a person's name. Here death is unverified; maternal suffering is continually reopened because an answer never arrives. The repeated touching of the sign and the calling of the name sustain karuṇa, while Burhbā's refusal to lie gives it an ethical steadiness. Fear, distress, and hope coexist, without the complete resolution sometimes afforded by mourning after confirmed death. No body or funeral is shown;

it would therefore be wrong to subsume the mother's condition entirely under the pathos of ordinary bereavement.

Bidesiyā and Aucitya: The Reader's Legitimate Questions

The song's courtyard, bundle of possessions, sweat of labor, and movement of money furnish vivid signs of separation from home. Yet its rebuke of the migrant who fails to send a name risks attributing guilt. Rāmsevak's silence is unexplained, and it cannot fairly be made the ground for accusing him of abandoning his mother. The bidesiyā tune is appropriate to the social atmosphere of migration, but the generalizations of folk song do not encompass every individual circumstance. A novel committed to preserving persons' names must also ask whether those persons receive an adequate opportunity to speak before being morally judged.

Classifying Incongruities: Song, Prose, Paratext, and Magical Rules

Several textual differences must be kept distinct. First, the folk song mentions letters and money orders, whereas Rāmsevak sends no news in the prose. Second, the dawn departure of the song and the mother's night of farewell in the prose differ in their temporal indications without producing an unavoidable contradiction. Third, “seven seas” is a poetic image, while the destination is unnamed. Fourth, the commentary's indenture history is comparative context, not an established biography of this character. Fifth, Burhbā's earlier water-pervading existence sits uneasily beside his local limitation here. Sixth, Rāmsevak is absent but not confirmed dead. These points belong to different levels of evidence and should not be solved by conjecture.

Videha Parallel History: The Absent Worker's Right to a Name

Even if a labor contract registered a migrant's name, geographical separation could leave that person socially invisible at home. Jānakī's observance seeks to preserve a poor, incompletely literate worker's place in local memory. It therefore becomes an ethical resource for a parallel history of marginalized lives. Yet the story reproduces no authentic colonial ship register or full copy of Rāmsevak's agreement. The ritual must not be passed off as a certified historical record of migration. Documentary verification is important for historical scholarship; fidelity and continuity of family remembrance have a different, potentially complementary, value.

Social Inequality: A Name Preserved, Physical Safety Uncertain

Calling his name reduces Rāmsevak's disappearance from the community's awareness, but it does not repair the consequences of an unread contract, the pressures of poverty, or the absence of contact. The chapter succeeds at

creating an institution of memory; it presents no systematic policy for protecting the migrant worker physically or economically. The difference between communal compassion and structural justice in labor relations remains open. If remembrance is made to stand for every kind of solution, exploitation and disappearance may become invisible once more. The review identifies the boundaries of the proposed institution without inventing a specific criminal outcome.

Overall Critical Judgment: A New Ethics of Truthful Not-Knowing

The chapter's strongest achievement lies in the relation between Burhbā's "I do not know" and Jānakī's practice of remembrance. Where the facts cannot decide whether a migrant is living or dead, the village protects his right to a name rather than manufacturing certainty. The mother's long wait, the touching of a stone or thread, recurrent observance on new-moon nights, and Rāmsevak's voiceless absence lend the narrative its pathos. The limitations remain significant: no account of the worker's actual life abroad, no clear terms of the written contract, no personal name for the mother, and a song of letters and remittances discordant with the prose's silence. A balanced reading regards the chapter as an affecting origin story about social memory, not a complete economic history of migration.

Source Discipline and the Following Chapter

The primary source is Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter [–67], "The Call from Abroad," index-derived pages 249–252. The bidesiyā song "A Letter from Abroad," the prose exchanges involving the broker, Rāmsevak, his mother, and Jānakī, and the commentary referring to indenture are distinct textual materials. The migrant's destination, the written contract's actual terms, his employment, whether he lived or died, correspondence, and his mother's own name remain unknown. Chapter [–66], "The Women's Night Assembly," turns to women's right to speak, the public use of the night, and the conditions under which a community may exercise authority in deciding disputes.

Critical Section 35 | Original Chapter −66 — The Women's Night Assembly

The Prehistory · Women's testimony, domestic violence, judicial authority, social pressure, and the institutionalization of communal memory

Textual Boundaries, Original Composition, and the Central Question

Chapter [−66], "The Women's Night Assembly," begins on page 253 of the original table of contents; Chapter [−65] begins on page 257. Pages 253–256 are therefore an approximate printed span, not verified individual page references for each quotation. The proverb, the night-assembly song "Voices that Break the Darkness," the prose narrative of Sulochanā, Padmā, and Burhbā, and the authorial commentary entitled "The Historical Role of a Parallel Institution of Women's Justice" constitute distinct textual levels. A general tribute to women's courage is insufficient as criticism of this chapter. The central question is how Padmā's demand for justice, rejected by the formal court, enters an independent hearing among women, and how much effective authority that hearing possesses.

The earlier classification is not a fresh measurement of textual quantity or event density. The critical reading therefore follows the actual events: the new court's neglect of women's cases, Padmā's unsuccessful petition, Sulochanā's objection, the remembrance of Ratnā, Gaurī, and Phulesarī, the establishment of an institution, the hearing of testimony, the communal decision, and the claim of subsequent permanence. Each must be examined in relation to the distribution of power within the narrative.

"Voice" and "Darkness" in the Proverb: An Ethical Resonance

The opening line, "Where women's voices gather, darkness grows thin," presents collective speech as an ethical force that reduces darkness. Darkness signifies not only the physical absence of daylight but potentially fear, shame, dismissal, and oppression. The assertion that a night assembly "breaks darkness even without a lamp" derives its figurative power from the possibility that hearing others precedes and enables social change. Yet the metaphor does not establish that a particular assembly took place in literal darkness or without lighting. The prose does not describe the illumination of its meeting place. Keeping the figurative meaning distinct from the event preserves both the poetry and the boundaries of the evidence.

The Collective Agency of the Song "Voices that Break the Darkness"

The song's first stanza gathers women's voices; the second opens a corner of the courtyard to speech about the heart; the third makes shared suffering a means of reducing fear; and the final stanza announces collective fearlessness. The presence of listeners for an individual woman's grief becomes the basis of social courage. No particular magistrate, dowry petition, or judicial ruling appears in the song: it is an emotional prefiguration of an assembly. Padmā's hearing and Sulochanā's institutional effort give narrative form to its communal principle, but every line of the song cannot be treated as an independently witnessed event in Padmā's case.

"A Corner of the Courtyard" in the Song versus the Institution's Public Form

In the lyric, women speak after dusk in a corner of the courtyard. In the principal narrative, Sulochanā confers an organized identity upon the older chhauṅkī assembly, and Burhbā describes it as standing by its own name in the village's light. The movement from a domestic, relatively private site toward public recognition is narratively significant. The prose, however, specifies no exact building, courtyard, entrance, or permanent meeting site for the new assembly. "Light" should not become a claim about the physical lighting of a hall, nor should the lyric's courtyard be imposed upon the particular hearing of Padmā. The spatial change is primarily symbolic and institutional.

"No Ghost Will Frighten Them": The Language of Overstatement

The song declares that "no ghost will frighten" women who stand together. This is an optimistic exaggeration of resistance, not an empirically established rule about their complete safety. Padmā has endured prolonged violence, a judge has dismissed her claim, and the new assembly's decisions lack formal legal enforceability. Those facts do not show that danger has disappeared. The ghost image can also anticipate the title of the next chapter, "The Procession of Fake Ghosts," but its events have not yet occurred here. The chorus voices hope, not the definitive cancellation of risk.

From Jānakī to Sulochanā: Succession through the Maternal Line

The narrative states that the responsibility for the observance passed from Jānakī to her daughter Sulochanā. In Chapter [–67], Jānakī had devised a form of remembrance for migrants whose fate was unknown; her daughter now brings domestic violence and women's justice into the public sphere. This is a generational transfer of cultural responsibility, not

a repetition of identical roles. Jānakī develops a procedure of remembrance for persons missing across the divide between life and death; Sulochanā creates a forum for decisions about women's immediate physical safety. The text gives neither the date nor the electoral procedure of succession. "After Jānakī" cannot independently establish her death or a specific administrative appointment.

The Court's "Good Intentions" and Its Failure in Women's Cases

The narrator describes weaknesses in the new court's treatment of women's cases "despite all its good intentions." Domestic disputes, dowry, inheritance, and cruelty by husbands appear as distinct avenues through which legal institutions intersect women's lives. Yet four separate litigations are not narrated. Only Padmā's experience of violence is developed as a particular case. The breadth of the rights problem must therefore be acknowledged without turning the enumeration into four proven case histories. The reference to good intentions also makes institutional failure a structural deficiency rather than simply the wickedness of one villain.

The Husband's Violence: The Bitter Center of Padmā's Experience

Padmā, a woman of the village, is beaten by her husband "for years." The statement specifies a prolonged experience, not a single fleeting quarrel. The narrative also reports the testimony of women who saw marks of injury and heard her crying. It does not provide an incident-by-incident chronology, medical treatment, a particular weapon, or a separately described immediate threat to her life. Inventing further terrifying scenes in order to intensify compassion would breach the source. Padmā's experience is central to the social structure of the chapter, not merely an illustration appended to Burhbā's moral instruction.

Padmā Goes to Court: A Claimant of Rights, Not a Passive Victim

After enduring sustained violence, Padmā goes to court to seek justice. This act establishes her agency: she refuses to accept that silence is an unavoidable condition of the abuse she has suffered, and appeals to the formal institution. A reading that makes her solely a helpless recipient of Sulochanā's rescue would suppress this initial resistance. The prose does not reproduce the precise words of her petition, list submitted documents, identify witnesses before the court, or describe a written order. The evidence of agency is her journey to claim justice, not a detailed record of litigation which the text does not supply.

The Judge's "Domestic Matter": The Categorical Diminution of Violence

Hearing Padmā's appeal, the judge says, "This is a domestic matter. A matter between husband and wife; it should be settled outside the court." The decisive injustice in this answer is a change of category: years of violence are displaced from a question of rights into the private sphere of marital accommodation. The scene reports this reply from one particular judge. It does not establish that every judge in every period delivered the same decision. In Padmā's case, however, the failure of access to justice is an explicit narrative event.

From the Court's First Hearing Date to the Unheard Voice at Home

Chapter [–68] showed how five years of procedural delay damaged poor farmer Bholā's ability to enjoy a legal right. Here Padmā's claim is dismissed at the threshold as a "domestic matter." The two episodes diagnose different failures of formal justice: the first concerns the cost of waiting; the second, refusal to recognize a grievance as judicially relevant. They should not be compressed into the sentence "the court is bad." Bholā ultimately receives a favorable ruling; Padmā obtains no such outcome from her encounter with the court. The institutional criticism is therefore multidimensional rather than uniform.

Sulochanā's Anger: From Feeling to Institutional Action

Angered by Padmā's experience, Sulochanā goes before Burhbā at the peepal and says, "This is not a domestic matter; it is injustice." The utterance claims the right to name an event. What the judge has set aside as private, she redescribes as a social and ethical wrong. Her anger begins an act of judgment rather than functioning as blind emotion. Yet it does not instantly stop the abuse. The subsequent stages—forming an institution, hearing evidence, and issuing a decision—must be followed in order to assess the productive significance of that anger.

The Peepal as a Place of Counsel: Burhbā and Women's Self-Determination

Sulochanā brings the question to Burhbā. He recalls an earlier tradition of women's meetings, but does not himself deliver a courtroom-style verdict against Padmā's husband. With Phulesarī's descendants and other women, Sulochanā establishes the new body. Burhbā thus supplies a link to remembered knowledge while women collectively undertake institutional decisions. Assigning all credit to Burhbā would suppress the women's leadership; denying his advisory role would be equally unfaithful. The

literary task is to distinguish the unequal yet complementary forms of agency involved.

Ratnā, Gaurī, and Phulesarī: A Long Memory of Women's Knowledge

Burhbā names Ratnā, Gaurī, and Phulesarī, who once sat on the evening chhauṅkī and shared knowledge, justice, and strategy. The invocation prevents the new assembly from appearing as an invention emerging from an empty social past. It becomes the public institutional development of generations of informal resistance. An earlier episode, [–91], presents Phulesarī as a leader in Ratnā's tradition of women's meetings and connects Gaurī to accusations of witchcraft. The women are present here through memory; the chapter does not say that Ratnā and Gaurī themselves are alive and participating in Sulochanā's hearing.

Gaurī of the Leatherworkers' Settlement and the History of Unequal Power

The earlier Gaurī episode concerns a knowledgeable woman from the leatherworkers' quarter who faces accusations of witchcraft and the threat of removal from land. In the present chapter, that struggle is recalled through Burhbā's naming of her. No currently speaking representative of Gaurī's settlement is identified in Padmā's hearing. The intertext suggests that the suppression of women's knowledge may involve caste status and coercive social power as well as gender. Yet Padmā's caste, economic position, and particular experience of caste discrimination remain unspecified. Gaurī's social identification must not be transferred to Padmā by inference.

From the Darkness of the Chhauṅkī to Light: A Metaphor of Recognition

Burhbā says that women's justice has emerged from the dark chhauṅkī to stand publicly in the village light under its own name. Here darkness describes the limited public prestige of private meetings; light connotes communal recognition. This does not mean that the older gathering was ignorant, false, or lacking in judgment: Burhbā explicitly values its knowledge, justice, and strategy. The transformation is from relative secrecy to public legitimacy, not a simple linear progress from ignorance to wisdom. The language of darkness and light should not inadvertently devalue the prior women's intellectual work.

"Phulesarī's Descendants": An Unnamed Participating Group

The principal narrative credits "Phulesarī's descendants and the other women of the village" with founding the assembly alongside Sulochanā. It gives neither the descendants' names, their number, a detailed genealogy,

nor their particular motivations. The collective expression powerfully suggests historical continuity but does not construct the individual lives of that family. A critic must not fill it with an invented lineage. The significance is that the tradition returns through identifiable earlier names and intergenerational relationships rather than through an entirely abstract collective of women.

Formalization: Name, Purpose, and Repetition

Sulochanā and the others establish an institution called "The Women's Night Assembly." It is not represented as a single accidental gathering: the narrative says that it heard cases involving domestic violence, dowry, and inheritance, and in time became a permanent part of village life. The naming of an institution, recurring work, and a claim of permanence supply the minimal narrative stages of formalization. No written constitution, election method, membership criterion, coercive power, or appellate system appears. "Formal" here means a publicly recognized and organized tradition, not a court registered by the state.

"Parallel" to the Official Court: Coexistence, Not Complete Replacement

The night assembly is said to operate "parallel to the official court," not to have displaced it. Padmā's petition is turned away by the latter and then heard by the former. The parallel body addresses a gap experienced within formal justice. But the story gives no procedure for resolving contradictory decisions by the two institutions, nor does it establish whether state law protects the assembly's social pressure. The narrative achievement is the emergence of another center of social responsibility, not a complete reconstruction of legally enforceable public authority.

"Not Legally Binding": The Explicit Limit of the Decision

One particularly important sentence states that the night assembly's decisions "were not legally binding." Any rigorous criticism must place this limitation at the center. Increased moral prestige does not turn its ruling into a judicial decree. The narrator does report that social pressure often made men comply. Legal obligation and communal acquiescence, however, represent distinct kinds of authority. Their relationship also leaves unresolved the possible conflict between procedural impartiality and local social pressure.

Social Pressure: Solidarity and Collective Control

The combined voices of women give Padmā a hearing that her own domestic position could not secure. But collective pressure is not inherently just in every possible instance. The text does not specify members' rights to

dissent, the ability of an accused person to give a reasoned answer, or procedures for correcting mistaken testimony. Here the account supports Padmā through the reported injuries and crying; still, a permanent institution requires independent consideration of procedural justice. Collective solidarity can strengthen a victim and, in other circumstances, constrain dissent. That is a critical possibility, not an additional injustice shown to have happened in this story.

The Husband and His Family Are Summoned: Hearing the Other Side

The assembly summons Padmā's husband and his family to a hearing. This supplies a rudimentary procedural element beyond the expression of emotion by a single party. The family initially denies the accusation. Their denial matters: the new assembly does not appear to pass sentence without making any attempt to hear the other side. Yet the separate words of husband and relatives, cross-examination, admission, independent evidence, or written undertaking are not provided. Summoning an opposing side begins a hearing; it does not prove that a complete and impartial adjudication took place.

Injury Marks: The Body as an Object of Direct Evidence

Women testify that they saw marks of injury on Padmā. Such marks give the narrative a concrete basis of observed bodily damage. But the dates of observation, medical causes, and independent record of each assault are not supplied. The observation of a mark is distinct from legal proof that a particular act by the husband caused each wound. The narrator explicitly states the long-term abuse by the husband; the witnesses' observation gives that narrative fact a social form of corroboration within the story.

Heard Crying: The Difference between Compassion and Proof

The women also testify to hearing Padmā weep. This auditory experience brings suffering that was hidden behind the phrase "domestic matter" into public hearing. Hearing someone cry may directly attest distress, but it does not on its own establish every cause, date, or responsible actor in a sequence of violence. The chapter combines narrated abuse, visibly reported injury, and the women's heard experience. These evidentiary levels should not be flattened into a single undifferentiated form of proof. Compassion and an enforceable judgment call for related but distinct standards.

"Every Woman in the Village": Testing a Universal Expression

The prose states that "every woman in the village, one by one, gave her testimony." The universal form magnifies the scale of solidarity. Yet the number, ages, castes, individual statements, and actual attendance of the

women are not given. “Every” may also be a narratorial device for the ideal of shared moral purpose. Whether anyone dissented and how women from marginalized or distant neighborhoods participated remain unanswered. A narrative claim of unanimity is not a census or a historical record demonstrating the absence of dissent.

Many Women's Voices and the Narrator's Uniform Presentation

Although the narrator says that women spoke in sequence, no named witness is allowed a long, independent speech. Observed injuries and heard crying become collective categories of testimony. The compression makes communal strength vivid while leaving individual experiences largely invisible. Sulochanā and Padmā are named; the many other women remain mostly anonymous. The tension between an asserted plurality of voices and the narrator's homogenizing presentation is a genuine limitation. We cannot add imagined dialogue and claim that the drama staged each witness's life in full.

The Husband's Family “Bends”: Admission, Fear, or Changed Conduct?

After the women speak together, the husband's family has to “bend.” This conveys the immediate effect of communal pressure, but leaves the nature of their submission uncertain. Did they admit guilt, apologize, accept an informal settlement, or actually change their later behavior? The narrative records a directive from the assembly without documenting subsequent compliance. It does not establish that the husband reformed, that the violence ended permanently, or that Padmā lived safely thereafter. The episode reaches a preliminary decision, not a narrated follow-up assessment.

The Directive to Reform and the Missing Result

The assembly instructs the husband to correct his conduct. The order refuses to treat domestic violence as an unalterable private habit; it makes the behavior publicly accountable. But there is no specified measure of reform, deadline, monitoring, compensation, or narrated outcome. An injunction to reform is a future-oriented demand; actual reform is not an event the prose confirms. The moral achievement of the directive and the uncertainty of Padmā's safety must remain visible together.

The Condition of Further Violence and a Woman's Freedom

The assembly decides that if the husband beats Padmā again, she will be free to return to her maternal home. The community explicitly recognizes her freedom of movement, but why is that freedom conditioned upon another assault when she has already endured years of abuse? The ruling

offers some social protection while leaving immediate self-determination unresolved. The text does not directly report what Padmā herself wished to do at that moment.

The Maternal Home: A Possible Refuge, Not an Established Remedy

Padmā's parental household is envisaged as a refuge, yet nothing is said about her parents, the house, available income, its willingness to receive her, or a lasting right of residence. What is described is the possibility of shelter, not completed rehabilitation. Security requires more than permission to leave an abusive husband; it also depends on means of subsistence. The story does not test those material conditions. Their absence should be recognized, not supplied through an imaginary account of assistance.

Padmā's Child: An Unnamed Dependent

The assembly promises help to "Padmā and her child." This detail extends the social consequences of violence beyond the spouses to another generation. But the child's name, age, condition, experience of trauma, and wishes are absent. Inventing these details would not be faithful to the literary evidence. The significance of the mention is that the promise of protection includes a dependent person as well as Padmā herself.

The Village's Offer of Help: A Pledge, Not Its Execution

The village promises to assist Padmā and her child. It does not specify food, protection, housing, money, legal support, or any other resource that is demonstrably delivered. Assistance functions here as an ethical commitment, not a completed administrative plan. This recalls Kamalinī's promise of "help, advice, and companionship" in Chapter [–68]. In both cases, honoring the promise's moral value requires distinguishing it from independent evidence of implementation.

Communal Guardianship and Padmā's Right to Decide

The assembly issues a decision, but Padmā's final consent or objection is not quoted directly. The family receives instructions to reform, and Padmā receives conditional permission to return to her parents. Community authority offers protection, but its representative decision does not automatically coincide with the affected woman's independent choice. The institution is therefore an important beginning of women's liberation, not a fully realized order of self-determination.

Padmā Named, the Husband Unnamed: A Choice of Perspective

The narrator names Padmā while leaving her husband unnamed. This enables the woman to appear as a particular human being rather than

simply somebody's wife. The husband is an anonymous representative of an abusive relationship. The ethical center lies with Padmā, while the accused family's separate history and psychological complexity remain undeveloped. Such uneven characterization is a narrative choice, not the complete record of an actual legal case.

Sulochanā Speaks; Padmā's Words Are Rarely Heard

Sulochanā speaks directly to Burhbā. Padmā goes to court, and the assembly hears her case, but the precise words of Padmā's own appeal are not reproduced. Despite the emphasis on "women's voices," the affected individual's speech is largely represented by the group around her. Her agency in seeking formal justice is demonstrated, but her direct voice concerning the final decision over her life remains limited. This is a central problem of representation in the chapter.

The Sequence of Events: A Hearing Grounded in the Story

The ascertainable chain is: prolonged beating of Padmā; dismissal by the court; Sulochanā's anger; Burhbā's remembrance of the old chhauṅkī; establishment of a new body; the summons to husband and family; women's testimony about injury marks and crying; the initial denial; collective pressure; and the directive to reform. Police action, medical certificates, an identifiable case number, a written settlement, an appeal, and a later repetition or cessation of the violence do not appear. Event density must be judged from these narrated changes, not invented legal procedures.

Narrative Time: Years of Abuse and a Brief Hearing

Generational succession, Padmā's abuse "for years," the history of Ratnā, Gaurī, and Phulesarī, and the claimed permanence of a later institution all fit within relatively short prose. The hearing itself receives more immediate narrative focus. Its particular day, duration, number of sessions, and hours remain unstated. The compression facilitates the scope of an epic narrative, but it reduces the representation of the long struggle through which institutions actually become established.

Night: Time for Speech after Women's Labor

The song says that evening has fallen and daily work is done before women gather. Its timing suggests a conflict between domestic labor and independent speech: daylight is occupied by work, while night becomes an opportunity to share experience. The prose does not inventory the occupations or distribution of labor of the women attending Padmā's hearing. Thus the song supplies an important social resonance, not a complete labor survey. A meeting after dark creates an opening without

proving equal participation by women in public institutions during the day.

The Absent Lamp: Figurative Meaning, Not a Literal Event

The lyric's light generated by voices, even without a lamp, represents moral illumination. The prose does not show Padmā's hearing conducted entirely in the dark. Claiming actual darkness could produce an internal difficulty alongside the reported observation of physical injuries. The artistic value lies in figurative suggestion, while the documentary status of lighting remains unspecified.

The Rasas: Compassion, Anger, and an Incomplete Reconciliation

Padmā's long suffering establishes karuṇa; Sulochanā's explicit anger suggests raudra; collective testimony supplies energy and commitment; Burhbā's satisfaction gestures toward śānta. Yet no scene proves Padmā permanently safe, so the final tranquility does not reach complete fulfillment. The progression of emotions expresses a continuing ethical struggle rather than an uncomplicated happy ending. Those emotions must be grounded in the characters' words and narrated actions, not invented private reactions attributed to other women.

Home and Assembly, Darkness and Light: Two Sides of Suggestion

The judge calls the violence a "domestic matter" and leaves Padmā's suffering inside the home; the night assembly brings it into public discussion. The transformation generates a linked symbolic opposition of home and community, darkness and light. But there is no evidence about how Padmā's privacy was safeguarded during the public hearing. Recognition of a woman's voice and her control over the exposure of her personal life remain distinct questions.

Subject, Probandum, and Reason: Care with Evidentiary Logic

The narrator states that the husband repeatedly beat Padmā. The women saw marks of injury and heard her cry, providing bases for communal testimony. In a Navya-Nyāya analysis Padmā's case can be treated as the pakṣa, the injustice of the violence as the sādhya, and the narrated abuse supported by bodily and auditory evidence as the hetu. But the specific scientific cause, time, and circumstances of each injury are not documented. Narratorial truth within the story and a legally established judicial conclusion belong to different evidentiary categories.

Visual and Auditory Evidence and Their Respective Limits

Seeing Padmā's wounds conveys visual information; hearing her crying conveys auditory information. The text does not say that every woman

directly witnessed the husband strike her. Seeing the physical mark of an injury is not identical to directly witnessing the act that produced it. The narrator does establish the husband's abuse, and the collective testimony serves to corroborate that narrative assertion socially. Such epistemic precision prevents the communal consensus from becoming an object of unexamined praise.

Majority and Truth: A Risk within Communal Adjudication

The picture of the entire community of women speaking with one voice carries considerable force. The narrator's statement of abuse supplies a moral basis for unanimity in this particular matter. Yet agreement by a majority is not an infallible proof of truth in all future disputes. The chapter gives no mechanism for mistaken testimony, dissent among members, or minority rights. Raising these questions is not opposition to the institution; it is an inquiry into the evidentiary demands of justice.

From the History of Witchcraft Accusations to Organized Resistance

Chapter [–91] includes Phulesarī's leadership within Ratnā's chhauṅkī tradition and accusations of witchcraft against Gaurī. The present section turns that earlier form of informal women's knowledge into a claim to publicly recognized justice. But no new witchcraft accusation occurs in Padmā's case, and no formal reconsideration of the older wrong takes place. The intertextual echo of a long history must be kept distinct from this episode of domestic violence.

Social Inequality and the Reach of "Every Woman"

Earlier Gaurī belongs to the leatherworkers' quarter; Padmā's caste and the night assembly's membership by caste are not described. "Every woman in the village" announces a comprehensive ideal, but supplies no inventory demonstrating equal rights of participation for poor, Dalit, widowed, unhoused, or professionally distinct women. The method of Videha Parallel History requires those absences to be questioned without filling them through invented claims about Padmā's caste or newly imagined incidents of injustice.

Three Levels of Authority: Court, Assembly, and Padmā

The court possesses formal state authority, the women's assembly local social authority, and Padmā herself is the person seeking justice. The state representative dismisses the case; the assembly makes it public, while Padmā's direct voice about her final personal choice is scarcely heard. Keeping these three levels apart allows the new institution to be valued without confusing communal guardianship with a woman's autonomous decision-making.

The Limit of Inferring Results: Did the Husband Change?

The family submits, and the assembly issues a directive: these are narrated facts. Whether the husband ceased abusing Padmā, whether she returned to her parents, whether the child became safe, and whether the village delivered help remain unreported. Her case therefore has no demonstrated final resolution. The assembly's origin story may be judged successful as an institutional beginning while justice in the victim's subsequent life remains uncertain.

The Limits of External Legal-Historical Claims

A judge and a new court are depicted, but the country, date, statutory provision, jurisdiction, and applicable law on domestic violence are not identified. Modern Indian legal requirements should not be silently imposed upon this fictional setting. The post-chapter explanation offers social commentary, not a verified archive of legal cases.

Temporal Compression: From Chhauṅkī to Permanent Assembly

The old gatherings of Ratnā, Gaurī, and Phulesarī, Sulochanā's establishment of the new body, and its projected reappearance in a later modern setting are compressed into a handful of paragraphs. The advantage is an impression of long social continuity; the cost is the absence of intermediate conflicts, membership struggles, and material resources. The narrator states that the assembly acquired permanence, but does not dramatize every process that secured that outcome.

The Paratextual Limits of Future Recurrence

An introductory comment anticipates the return of the night assembly's name in Part I of the broader work. That is foreshadowing, not evidence for the participants, legal powers, or circumstances of the future chapter. A shared title does not prove that every later event has already occurred in this prehistory.

The Narrative Pattern of an Ethical Institution's Birth

Padmā's rejected appeal, Sulochanā's resistance, Burhbā's recollection, the women's collective founding, the testimony, and the decision form a definite institutional origin story. The section is therefore more than a generalized moral sermon: it has a sequence of consequential actions. Still, its regular procedures and the long-term safety of Padmā are left undescribed. Its achievement and its limits must be held together.

An Inventory of the Principal Textual Tensions

Seven tensions stand out: the song's exaggerated assurance that no ghost can frighten women, in contrast to Padmā's actual danger; rejection by the court versus social authority within the assembly; the community's collective voice versus the scarcity of Padmā's own spoken words; a directive to reform versus no demonstrated result; permission to return to her parents only in the event of further violence; a universal claim that every woman testified despite the anonymity of individual social groups; and the designation of the older chhauṅkī as darkness although it was itself a repository of women's knowledge. These are not identical factual errors. They include problems of narrative selection, ethical tension, and absent evidence.

Overall Critical Assessment

"The Women's Night Assembly" achieves particular literary force by moving Padmā's suffering out of the judge's dismissive category of a "domestic matter" and into the domains of public testimony and communal demand for justice. Sulochanā's leadership, Phulesarī's descendants, the women's testimony regarding wounds and crying, and the express admission that the decisions lack legal force make the account unusually substantial. But the actual implementation of the ruling, Padmā's autonomous final wishes, her immediate safety, and the procedural fairness of social pressure are unresolved. This is a conditionally successful story of an institution's origins, not a complete record of individual restoration.

Primary Source and the Next Chapter

Primary text: Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, complete trilogy, Volume 0, Chapter [−66], "The Women's Night Assembly," pages 253–256 according to the table of contents. The proverb, the folk song "Voices that Break the Darkness," the prose account of Padmā, Sulochanā, and Burhbā, and the subsequent authorial discussion of a parallel institution of women's justice are separately identified. The following Chapter [−65], "The Procession of Fake Ghosts," concerns the manufacture of fear, social deception, and the testing of evidence.

Critical Section 36 | Original Chapter −65 — The Procession of Fake Ghosts

The Prehistory · Performance, the economics of deception, tests of testimony, and the social manufacture of fear

Section Boundaries and Levels of the Text

"The Procession of Fake Ghosts," Chapter [−65], begins on page 257 of the original contents, and Chapter [−64] begins on page 261; the approximate printed range is therefore 257–260. Its opening proverb, the folk song "Who Are You?", the prose narrative of Harinandan, Kālīcharaṇ, and Burhbā, and the subsequent commentary on exploitation must be considered separately. The staging of counterfeit ghosts, the commercial misuse of Burhbā's reputation, a family's financial loss, a simple rule of verification, and the fraudster's flight form another narrative of social origins. Its primary achievement is not the negation of folk belief but an examination of the method by which authority is falsely claimed in the name of a respected tradition.

The figures mentioned in the earlier plan are indicators of textual length and organization, not a new independent count of events. The specific analytical focus is "staging, performance, and the collective gaze." The authority of spectators, actors, organizers, genuine witnesses, and transmitters of warnings must therefore be distinguished. The fake-ghost procession is not dramatized in detail as one continuous scene; it appears largely through narratorial description and subsequent reports. Counting the song's imagined public unmasking as a second enacted episode in the prose would artificially inflate the event count.

Harinandan, Sulochanā's Son: A New Turn in Succession

The text states that Sulochanā's son Harinandan assumes responsibility for the ritual after her. In the previous Chapter [−66], women established a public institution of communal justice; the successor now has to defend the reputation of that institution and Burhbā's remembered tradition from an outsider's fraud. Nothing about the familial relationship alone proves Sulochanā's death, a ceremony of selection, or receipt of a written appointment. Generational succession is a sequence of social responsibilities rather than an independently dated chronology. Harinandan becomes significant through his movement from indignation to consultation and the circulation of warnings among neighboring villages.

The Spread of Fame: The Fragility of Social Strength

According to the narrator, the fame of the night assembly and Burhbā's observance spreads into surrounding villages. Recognition enlarges public confidence but also creates a gap in direct knowledge: people in distant settlements hear Burhbā's name without necessarily knowing how his actual institution functions. Fraud emerges within that disparity. Burhbā calls it a "sad by-product of success," recognizing the two-edged quality of prestige. Fame alone is not established as a necessary or sufficient cause of fraud in all situations; it furnishes an opportunity which Kālīcharaṇ deliberately exploits.

Kālīcharaṇ: A Personalized Claim and the Paradox of a Name

The itinerant deceiver is called Kālīcharaṇ, yet advertises himself as "Burhbā's true spirit." Although he has a known name of his own, he drapes the symbolic authority of another being over his body. The novel's recurring question of name and body takes an inverse form: which name deserves credence, the name someone proclaims, or an identity tested against communal conduct? The narrative does not give Kālīcharaṇ's home, caste, earlier life, full set of motives, or the permanent size of his group. His deception is explicit; no collective accusation against all mendicants, ascetics, or itinerant communities follows from it.

The Procession of Hired Ghosts: Costume, Light, and Drums

Kālīcharaṇ arranges a nighttime procession with assistants hired to play ghosts, their bodies wrapped in cloth and accompanied by lights. These are human performers, not genuine supernatural presences within the story. Disguise conceals identity; night makes the claim more suggestive; spectacle supplies a theatrical vocabulary of terror or astonishment. A sheet and drums are particularly present in the folk song. In the prose the costume and illumination are specified, but the precise action of a drum is not separately shown. The performed procession is a device of fraud, not a magical event.

Night's Darkness: An Opportunity for Fear, Not a Suspension of Evidence

A nighttime procession may weaken ordinary means of recognizing faces, and this is part of the scene's narrative possibility. Yet the text gives no reliable inventory of lamps, number of performers, streets, or exact hour. The song's heightened darkness makes spectators' fear imaginable. Kālīcharaṇ uses this atmosphere to circulate the claim that he embodies the real spirit. The villagers' fear should not be reduced to a proof of stupidity: unequal information, inherited trust, and the cultural

importance of remembrance create the circumstances in which the spectacle becomes persuasive.

Seeing and Acting: How the Meaning of an Observed Scene Changes

Spectators could observe wrapped human bodies and lights; that observation does not prove the arrival of "Burhbā's true spirit." Kālīcharaṇ translates visible costumes and illumination into an assertion of supernatural legitimacy. The separation between what is seen and the claim made about it generates the narrative conflict. The deceiver profits by collapsing these categories. Criticism must distinguish the observed arrangement, the interpretation placed upon it by the public, and the religious authority claimed in advertising. The epistemic difficulty of the novel's opening shell-and-silver episode is thus realized in an everyday economic crisis.

Collection of Money from Trusting Families: The Commerce of Fear

Kālīcharaṇ extracts money from vulnerable villagers while asserting that Burhbā requires a "special worship" to preserve their names. Here the exchange is not ordinary voluntary generosity; fear and fabricated authority are brought together for collection. The fraud is an established fact of the prose. The materials of the ceremony, amount per family, duration of collection, and exact threats used are not given. Thus the narrative exposes the social process of exploitation without supplying a complete criminal inventory. The central ethical issue is how a tradition of freely remembering names is converted into a fictitious commodity with a price.

An Entire Family's Savings: Economic and Ethical Injury

A family from a neighboring village gives Kālīcharaṇ its "entire savings" and, realizing it has been deceived, comes to Garh Nārikel. The loss is concrete even though the family's names, number of members, occupation, and amount of money are unknown. Those who paid are not simply fools. They subsequently seek verification from the genuine Burhbā, becoming active agents in the investigation of the deceptive claim. Their later recovery of the money, however, is not narrated. The correction of knowledge and the restitution of property must be treated as separate outcomes.

The Defrauded Family's Journey: From Confusion toward Verification

After the loss, the family travels to the village where it believes the authentic witness can be consulted. This creates a recognizable route by which a complaint and new information circulate. The story does not report compensation, refund, or financial rehabilitation for the family.

The tradition's reputation may eventually be protected while the specific victim's loss remains unresolved. The festive disappearance of the fraudster must not be allowed to conceal this unfinished individual story.

Harinandan's Anger and Burhbā's Silence: The Rhythm of the Episode

Harinandan reports that someone is defrauding people in Burhbā's name and asks how the practice can be stopped. Burhbā remains silent for a long time. The pause does not immediately produce a call for revenge, arrest, or divine punishment; it leads toward a principle of discrimination. Its exact duration and the total sequence of Burhbā's private thoughts are not narrated. His later answer concerns reputation, imitation, and opportunism. The narrative movement thus carries an urgent incident from public outrage toward an articulated method of judgment.

The "Sad By-product of Success": Burhbā's Double Explanation

Burhbā calls the fraud a sad consequence of the tradition's success, rather than evidence that the original practice has failed. Its prestige becomes profitable to imitate. The observation does not relieve the family of the pain caused by its lost savings, and opportunity must still be distinguished from culpable individual action. The literary achievement is to make fraud a crisis of recognition produced partly by the spread of a valuable institution, not merely the eruption of a foreign villain. Yet it also raises a question the narrative scarcely answers: why was the authentic practice's means of verification not publicized before its reputation spread so widely?

"A True Witness Does Not Ask for Money": A Local Test

Burhbā offers a direct distinction: a true witness does not demand money, sell fear for profit, or trade the preservation of a name for payment; the authentic relationship offers love and memory. Within this fictional institution, the free character of remembrance becomes a negative rule of verification. A claimant who uses Burhbā's name to frighten people into paying violates the institution's own principles. It would be an unwarranted extension, however, to make this particular criterion a universal test of every religion, paid service, or public organization. Its proper scope is the specific promise made by the tradition in the novel.

Service Without a Charge and the Actual Cost of Providing It

Not demanding money does not necessarily mean that leaves, gatherings, songs, travel, and the care of memory require no materials or human labor. The book gives no complete account of those costs. Burhbā's ethical test addresses the especially deceptive demand for payment made under a false threat, not every possible form of voluntary communal contribution

or expenditure. This distinction protects the moral significance of free witness-bearing while leaving open the material conditions of sustaining the institution.

The Rule of Free Service and Its Unexplored Possibilities

Harinandan turns Burhbā's rule into a simple public saying. In this episode the maxim proves effective against Kālīcharaṇ's particular use of fear to extract payments. Yet the account ends with one man's flight. It does not demonstrate how the community would respond to future imitators who ask for no money, or who seek authority rather than immediate cash. The rule resolves the present episode in the fictional world; it is not an exhaustive guarantee against every later deception. The difference between the narrator's conclusive ending and a reader's remaining uncertainty is narratologically important.

"Selling Fear": The Economic Exchange of an Invisible Object

The real commodity in Kālīcharaṇ's business is fear, supposedly reducible by paying for "special worship." The folk song's image of a "market of fear" gains concrete force from the prose account of money collection. Fear is not merely a word: it is formed out of trust, the memory of death, and the longstanding desire to protect names. The metaphor of commercialization locates the moment when a collective emotion is converted into economic power. Explaining this mechanism is more fruitful than blaming those who were defrauded.

Harinandan's Campaign: The Outward Journey of a Simple Rule

After hearing Burhbā's answer, Harinandan carries the warning through nearby villages. The narrative briefly describes its spread, not individual public meetings in each settlement, written leaflets, or a named list of witnesses. The narrator summarizes the rule as sufficient to protect the public from the opportunists at hand. This is an immediate success claim within the fiction, not independent data about fraud rates or restitution. An instructive reversal occurs: deception spread through the movement of a celebrated name, and its exposure spreads along a similar network of communication. One medium serves opposed moral uses.

The Lamp-bearing Questioner in the Folk Song: A Scene Not Enacted in the Prose

The song imagines "one courageous voice" holding a lamp, asking "Who are you?", pulling away a sheet, and sending the ghost fleeing. The prose describes no such direct confrontation with the procession, no public removal of a costume, and no named lamp-bearing protagonist. Kālīcharaṇ sees his business collapse after Harinandan's warnings and

disappears by night. It would be a serious interpolation to say that Harinandan himself removed the sheet. The lyric offers a theatrical image of revelation; the prose relies on the gradual influence of information and the collapse of a market in false authority.

Spectators' Authority: "Who Are You?" as the Essential Act

In the lyric, "Who are you?" is a direct challenge on the stage of the procession. In the prose, the prohibition against extracting money and selling fear is the more systematic form of such a question. The spectator moves from passive audience member to examiner of a claim. The song's exchange is not a documented speech in the prose; the two forms express a related critical idea through different narrative devices. The social education in asking for identification acquires its meaning from the relation between these levels.

A Play within the Story: Actors and Observers

Kālīcharaṇ and the hired assistants turn a public space into a performance. Actors hide their actual identities, while spectators are led to attach supernatural significance to what appears before their eyes. It is theatre embedded in narrative, though there is no described permanent stage, written direction, or full script of their acting. The crucial narratological question concerns the difference between who sees and how the seen event is reported. Illumination both reveals and conceals; the deceiver's claimed authority grows within that difference.

The Characterization of the Authentic Witness

Burhbā does not demonstrate supernatural power in order to expose Kālīcharaṇ. He explains the identifying conduct of his own practice. The narrative moves the meaning of authentic tradition away from a spectacular miracle and toward the ethical proposition that one should remember names without selling fear. Harinandan disseminates that personal statement as a publicly usable principle. The text does not provide separate scenes involving other possible forms of impersonation; their verification remains unexamined.

Keeper of Names and Thief of a Name: An Inverted Symbol

Burhbā preserves names; Kālīcharaṇ appropriates Burhbā's name to obtain money. The longstanding motif of name and body gains a new reversal. The name trusted as a sign of remembrance is turned into an advertisement for a bogus procession. Kālīcharaṇ possesses a personal name but borrows another's authority. The episode thus supplies a metaphor of stealing a name without yet narrating the digital identity theft anticipated elsewhere in the larger work.

Information between Villages: The Geography of the Incident

The movement runs from neighboring villages to Garh Nārikel and then outward again. The fake procession travels among other communities; the defrauded family comes inward to seek verification; Harinandan then takes a warning outward. This three-part reversal makes space into a dynamic route of information and belief, rather than a static setting. The narrator gives neither every village's name nor the distances, but the directional movement creates a recognizable social network.

Kālīcharaṇ's Flight: An Incomplete Ending

When Harinandan's warning undermines the business, Kālīcharaṇ and his hired companions disappear one night. That is the narrated dramatic end; neither arrest, return of the savings, nor compensation to the harmed family follows. The aim of public warning may be regarded as achieved, but the victim's personal circumstances remain unsettled. A community-wide ending and an unrepaired individual loss must not be conflated.

Unnamed Assistants: Labor Behind the Costume

The assistants described as “hired ghosts” participate in the acting, yet their wages, relationships, degree of choice, and separate lives remain unknown. They produce the spectacle without developing as individual characters. This pairing of visible labor and silent personal identity matters in a broad social narrative. Criticizing the limited representation does not authorize an invented account of their motives or crimes.

The Unspecified Amount of Economic Loss

That one family surrendered its “entire savings” conveys an intense proportional loss. The amount, profession of the family, and total number of affected households remain unknown. The story exposes the moral shape of exploitation, not a detailed economic survey. “Entire” describes the significance of the loss within a family's life, not an identifiable currency sum. Criticism must not expand a compact statement of injury into a fabricated ledger of numerous victims.

The Proverb's Laughter and the Prose's Grief

The proverb pictures someone who knows the true name laughing at the ghostly procession. In the prose, Harinandan is angry, Burhbā saddened, and the cheated family economically harmed. The lyric's victorious laughter and the narrative's initial pathos sound different. The divergence permits theatrical pleasure in the exposure of deception to coexist with the actual suffering produced by exploitation. To read only a comic victory would obscure the family's unrecovered savings.

The Emotional Movement: From Fear toward Discernment

Darkness and the procession create fear; the family's loss produces compassion; Harinandan's anger gives energy to resistance; Burhbā's reflective silence and answer lend the sequence a calmer deliberative rhythm. The folk song adds a comic or triumphant unmasking, whereas the prose rests upon dissemination of a warning. The distinct artistic modes expand the experience without becoming identical accounts of the same narrated scene.

Unequal Knowledge between Reader and Characters

The narrator calls the performers "hired" ghosts from the outset. The reader therefore knows the deception before the characters who pay money understand it. The chapter's tension does not primarily ask whether the ghosts are real; it asks how the community will put a stop to the trick. The contrast between reader and character knowledge creates dramatic irony. Harinandan's campaign provides the anticipated solution, making the story one of public discernment rather than a supernatural mystery gradually explained.

The Communal Ethics of Remembrance versus Commercial Fraud

Kālīcharaṇ's undertaking seeks his own gain; Burhbā's practice exists to preserve collective memory. The two competing uses of the same name organize the chapter's moral conflict. The contrast between extorting money through fear and remembering people without charge is visible in the events themselves. How the institution will confront more complex future uses of its prestige is not decided here.

The Birth and Repetition of a Warning Tale

The episode enters village memory under the name "The Procession of Fake Ghosts" and is retold to each new generation. An incident of personal fraud becomes a communal cautionary narrative. Repetition seeks to affect the conduct of future listeners, making the tale more than news of a past event. The novel does not depict every generation's retelling; the repeated transmission is a narratorial summary. This transformation into something like a folk warning story is a principal achievement of the chapter's construction.

Burhbā's Limited Role and Human Initiative

Burhbā does not magically banish Kālīcharaṇ or pull the sheets off the hired performers. He supplies a discriminating rule, while Harinandan communicates it to other settlements. Thus responsibility shifts from the supernatural custodian to the social actions of human characters. Burhbā's response directs the plot, but people carry it out. The defense of an

institution against the performance of a miracle relies on practical communication rather than a counter-miracle.

The Failure of the Performance: Defeat in the Intended Purpose

The counterfeit procession is staged to produce fear; once knowledge spreads, its economic utility disappears. The performance fails through a change in the audience's response, not through a magically produced rival show. The folk song stages the removal of a sheet; the prose abbreviates the campaign and the fraudster's flight. Identifying which mechanism actually ends the event is essential to studying the work's dramatic construction.

The Principal Difference between Folk Song and Prose

The lyric contains a drum, a lamp-bearing questioner, a public unmasking of the fake ghost, and an immediate flight. The prose instead presents the wronged family's journey, Harinandan's search for counsel, Burhbā's silence, public communication of the institution's rule, and Kālīcharaṇ's nocturnal departure. The courageous questioner of the song is not individually identified in the prose. No episode establishes that Harinandan personally removed the sheet. The two forms employ different rhythms: visual immediacy in the song, and the gradual social effect of communication in the prose.

Overall Narrative Assessment

"The Procession of Fake Ghosts" succeeds by showing that the very fame of a tradition devoted to preserving names can endanger it. The family's complaint and Harinandan's campaign change a passive audience into a potentially discerning public. The relation of actors and spectators, the staged production of fear, the dramatic unmasking imagined by the song, and the prose's account of informational change provide the main subjects of narratological criticism. Its limitations are equally plain: the family's money is not shown to be returned, the hired assistants remain unnamed, and the scene of physically unveiling the ghost appears only in the song. The result is a compact, effective warning tale, not a complete story of social restitution.

Source Note and the Following Sequence

Primary text: Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, Chapter [–65], approximate printed pages 257–260 from the table of contents. The proverb, the folk song "Who Are You?", the prose concerning Kālīcharaṇ and Harinandan, and the post-chapter commentary have been distinguished. The public removal of a sheet occurs only in the song, not in the prose. The next Chapter [–64], "Sukhdev's Revenge," will examine older land injustice, the passage of documents

through time, and the reorganization of a network of communal characters.

Critical Section 37 | Original Chapter –64 — Sukhdev's Revenge

The Prehistory · The title's promise of retaliation, the memory of land, intertextual recurrence, and the network of communal characters

The Chapter's Textual Basis and Narrative Compass

The original table of contents places Chapter [–64], "Sukhdev's Revenge," on pages 261–264; Chapter [–63] begins on page 265. The proverb, the folk song "The Path of Forgiveness," the prose land dispute involving Champāvatī and Raghubīr Singh, and the subsequent commentary entitled "The Power of Accumulated Communal Capacity" belong to different textual levels. The title raises the expectation of revenge, whereas the prose culminates in a victory concerning land rights in a court of law. This alteration of meaning enables the story to fashion a different form of heroism out of what might otherwise have been a narrative of violent retaliation.

The particular analytical questions concern place, time, repetition, and the movement from beginning through middle to end. These preliminary indicators do not constitute an independently measured density of events. The real trajectory runs from a fresh land survey through the recovery of old records, preparation for litigation, the support of the women's assembly, a court judgment, and Burhbā's final emotional interpretation. The narrative's operative axis is the reassembly of earlier achievements in documentation, education, and collective organization.

"Sukhdev's Revenge": An Expectation Reversed

In the idiom of folktales, "revenge" can suggest bloodshed, arson, or a private act of retribution. The prose, however, establishes from the outset that Champāvatī intends to answer a renewed historical injustice differently. After Raghubīr Singh loses his case, Burhbā calls this "Sukhdev's revenge," but specifies that it is revenge "not in the form of retaliation, but in the form of justice." The meaning of the title is thus determined anew in the final speech. Peaceful institutional success supplants the reader's initial anticipation.

Sukhdev in the Folk Song and Champāvatī in the Prose: A Decisive Difference

"The Path of Forgiveness" sings of a fire burning in Sukhdev's breast, the possibility of his carrying fire in his hands, and his eventual refusal to set anything alight. In the main prose narrative the presently active figure is Champāvatī; Sukhdev is the remembered victim of an earlier generation

rather than a character acting before us. There is no event in which a fire is set in the dispute with Raghubīr Singh, no scene of Sukhdev personally relinquishing vengeance, and no violent procession. Accordingly, the lyric's "one who chose forgiveness" cannot be cited as an event established by the prose. The song constructs an ethical exemplum; the main narrative presents social resistance supported by records.

The Echo of an Older Injustice: Sukhdev's Earlier Story

The preliminary commentary reports a renewed threat to the land of the leatherworkers' settlement, resembling the threat of Sukhdev Mahto's time. Champāvatī says that history seems to be returning. The ultimate outcomes, however, differ: in Sukhdev's age the opportunity to secure the right was lost; in Champāvatī's, preparation through documentation succeeds. Most importantly, the prose expressly denies a direct genealogical relationship between Raghubīr Singh and Ugrasen Thakur, the antagonist of the older episode. It would contradict the text to turn these opponents from distinct periods into members of one conspiratorial family.

"Merely a Similar Disposition": The Narrator's Explicit Qualification

In a parenthetical clarification the narrator says that Raghubīr Singh has no relationship with Ugrasen Thakur of Sukhdev's day: their dispositions merely resemble each other. This explanation separates the recurrence of social wrongdoing from hereditary determinism. Different people may employ comparable methods of laying claim to land. The recurrence is one of conduct and the use of power, not a continuity of blood. Through the parenthesis, the narrator anticipates and prevents a likely confusion on the reader's part.

From Harinandan to Champāvatī: The Rhythm of Generations

After Harinandan, his daughter Champāvatī assumes responsibility for the communal observance. Harinandan's action in Chapter [–65] concerned the circulation and correction of public information about fraud. Under Champāvatī, the institution confronts a land dispute organized around documentary proof. The family succession supplies a continuous cultural thread, while each generation meets a different crisis with different resources. The word "after" alone establishes neither a specific death nor a particular transfer-of-office ceremony.

The Fresh Revenue Survey: An Institutional Cause of Conflict

A new state revenue arrangement initiates another survey of the land. This external administrative change makes older forms of possession and communal entitlement vulnerable to challenge. The narrator does not reproduce the survey procedure, maps, or statements of revenue officials,

but the renewed measurement creates an opening for a new landlord's claim. Beneath the apparently personal language of revenge thus lies a concrete alteration in social administration. The historical redefinition of place supplies the conflict's institutional background.

The Land of the Leatherworkers' Quarter: A Community at the Center

The disputed property is the common land of the leatherworkers' settlement. It is not merely a geographical backdrop; it signifies the continuity of habitation and communal identity. The prose does not provide household-by-household ownership, the number of dwellings, the acreage, or agricultural returns. Many individual lives are consequently gathered beneath one collective place-name. The village's support becomes narratively important, but the limited direct speech of the settlement's actual residents also becomes a legitimate critical concern.

Raghubīr Singh: A Claim Formed through Language

The new landlord alleges that the old records were unclear and that the land belonged to his ancestors. Nothing in the account establishes personal enmity toward Sukhdev or a wish for revenge against him. Singh frames the dispute as one of legally recognizable entitlement, and Champāvatī counters it with documentary evidence. His personality is developed chiefly through the general resemblance of disposition noted by the narrator. His larger social life and reaction after defeat are not depicted. The work privileges his function as an opposing claimant over psychological complexity.

Champāvatī's First Response: Recollection Rather Than Panic

Hearing the news, Champāvatī does not panic. She tells Burhbā that "history is returning," but adds that they now possess a weapon unavailable in Sukhdev's era. Her response turns the memory of an earlier failure into the basis of a new decision. The "weapon" is a metaphor for the social and institutional means now at their disposal; no actual sword, firearm, army, or violent act of revenge appears. The narrative demonstrates what a community can learn from remembered injury.

From Conversation at the Peepal to the Archives: A Journey between Sites

Champāvatī first approaches Burhbā at the place of communal memory, then turns to the village archive. This spatial movement links the moral direction of oral testimony with the practical use of written history. The peepal remains a living witness to the long course of the narrative; the archive houses assembled written records. Neither medium wholly replaces

the other. To resolve the dispute, Champāvatī must move beyond an appeal to memory toward documents that can operate in a formal institutional setting.

Yādavānand Jhā's "Shadow Register": The Journey of a Copy

A copy of Yādavānand Jhā's personal notebook, the "shadow register," has been preserved in the village archive, while descendants continue to maintain the original tradition. These two paths enlarge the reach of memory through the copyability of documents. The narrative says that the register recorded the leatherworkers' land rights with dates and witnesses, but supplies neither a verbatim transcription nor every page's physical form or method of certification. As a narrative object, the register makes the past act upon the present; it is no mere antiquarian decoration.

Rights Dating Back to Somar and Ratnā: An Historical Thread among Characters

The register is said to record the land entitlement of the leatherworkers' quarter from the time of Somar and Ratnā. This mention joins the contemporary struggle over land to the work and memory of earlier generations, including histories of social and gendered marginalization. Somar and Ratnā do not speak in the present episode. Their names enter through the register. The ordering of voices is important: even when the historical participants themselves are absent, the record of their activity becomes a force capable of shaping a present decision.

Young Lawyers from the Coconut-Leaf School: Education Put to Work

Champāvatī summons educated young lawyers associated with the Coconut-Leaf School. The earlier educational enterprise here acquires an immediate practical function. The young lawyers' individual names, legal curriculum, specific submissions, and courtroom arguments are not given. Nevertheless, the association between school and advocates makes Champāvatī's action an outcome of accumulated communal education, rather than a solitary heroine's struggle. The conversion of education from an emblem of progress into a working capacity is a major transition in the chapter.

The Women's Night Assembly: A Causal Bridge between Chapters

The Women's Night Assembly, established in Chapter [–66], now mobilizes the village against Raghubīr's claim. Its earlier formation is therefore not merely recalled through a repeated title; the institution has continuing practical consequences. We are not told the number of meetings, the women who spoke, or the extent of decision-making authority exercised by women from the leatherworkers' settlement. Broad

support is presented through narratorial summary, not an extensive series of individual dialogues. This distinction matters to a close account of how the institution operates.

Haripati's Manuscript: From Personal Composition to Public Evidence

Haripati's old manuscript has survived through a succession of disciples and is produced in the present dispute. A literary manuscript thereby becomes a witness to the social history of land entitlement. The exact pages, language, account of the rights, and passages quoted before the court are not reproduced. The narrator establishes a long succession of custody and the document's present use, rather than printing its full text. The social function of writing changes inside the narrative: literature becomes practically relevant to a community's material claim.

The Combined Resources: Register, Education, and Women's Organization

Champāvatī does not rely upon a mysterious intervention. The dates and witnesses in the register, the legal capacity of the school's graduates, the village support mobilized by the women's assembly, and Haripati's manuscript contribute distinct resources toward a common aim. The union of these earlier narrative strands makes the novel's diverse persons and objects productive in a subsequent crisis. The literary benefit is an intelligible return on the story's long preparation. Its many beginnings have been kept alive long enough to become collective agency.

The Courtroom: An Outcome Told, an Argument Compressed

The prose reports that Raghubīr Singh is unable to offer substantial support for his claim and loses in court. A judge makes a short statement of praise, but the text does not recount day-by-day hearings, the order of witness examination, the opposing lawyer's submissions, or the full written judgment. The legal result is definite within the fiction; the procedure is only briefly presented. The accelerated pace gives priority to the communal significance of victory rather than to the suspense of a detailed courtroom drama.

The Judge's Perspective: The Institution Changes Roles

In Chapter [−68], prolonged judicial delay kept Bholā's case unresolved for five years; in [−66], a judge dismissed Padmā's experience of violence as domestic. In the present chapter a judge recognizes the coherence of the village records and rejects a landlord's unsupported claim. Three representations of courts thus coexist inside the same narrative world. It would be mistaken to say either that courts are invariably corrupt or that

they invariably dispense justice. Nothing establishes that the judges in these episodes are the same individual. The work varies an institution's function without developing continuity of character.

Victory in Land Rights: A Change of Situation

At the beginning of the chapter the leatherworkers' collective land is endangered by a newly asserted claim. At the end Singh has lost and the community's entitlement has been secured. This is the chapter's chief externally verifiable transition within its fictional world. Although the narrator tells us that the organized evidence impresses the court, the subsequent reactions of residents in their fields, homes, and courtyards are not separately dramatized. Champāvatī's conversations carry the emotional center of an outcome whose direct beneficiaries remain largely collective.

Burhbā's Speech: The Reunion of Previously Scattered Characters

The final speech brings together Yādavānand's notebook, Haripati's manuscript, Mandākinī's school, and Sulochanā's night assembly. Enterprises founded in different episodes now converge upon one result. Readers do not witness all those founders returning as physically present characters, but their works function as causes of the current victory. This is a technique of reunion within a long and expansive narrative, not simply a celebratory recital of famous names. At the same time, the relative weight of each older institution is not independently measured.

Burhbā's "Revenge": A Dramatic Transformation of Meaning

Burhbā declares that "Sukhdev's revenge" is justice, not retaliation. The title is thus rewritten at the point of conclusion. Sukhdev himself is absent: this is not an action he carries out but a success achieved by later members of the community in response to a wrong attached to his memory. Instead of staging a second cycle of violence, the chapter locates an answer to historical injury in the growth of social capacity. That symbolic response cannot literally undo Sukhdev's personal death and deprivation; it is the justice of inheritance and communal succession.

Champāvatī's Tears: The Emotional Moment of the Outcome

After the judgment, Champāvatī asks Burhbā through tears whether the struggles of their ancestors were therefore not in vain. Formal success meets inherited memory in this exchange. Tears may signify both relief and the grief that survives relief; the narrator does not confine them to one single emotion. Burhbā's answer gives meaning to the continuity of struggles. The judgment is thereby reread as an ethical response to earlier lives, not merely the successful submission of a set of papers.

Sukhdev's Own Voice: Present in Memory, Absent in the Scene

The title foregrounds Sukhdev; the song imagines his bodily anguish; the prose remembers his tragedy through Burhbā's words. Yet Sukhdev does not speak or act as a character in the present dispute. This mode of absence made present is central to the structure: a person's struggle acquires new meanings through later generations. The relatively limited testimony from living residents of the settlement remains a problem, however. Memory may speak loudly while some of the community's presently varied voices go unheard.

Narrative Echo: History Returns, but the Outcome Changes

Champāvatī's declaration that history is returning prepares the expectation of recurrence. The narrator does not make the two events identical. Earlier insecurity and a failed opportunity are answered by successful documentary resistance. Instead of history circling back to its original suffering, accumulated experience allows a different result. Repetition here is more than the return of pain; remembered institutions become resources for a new action. Comparison between episodes [−92] and [−64] therefore helps explain the novel's long temporal structure.

Land and Documents: A Narrative of Place

The land of the leatherworkers' quarter is a tangible site whose entitlement is secured again through written records. Place supplies the emotional center; the register carries knowledge of its historical identity. A literary object—the manuscript—becomes useful in a question of habitation and livelihood. Yet the maps, houses, pond boundaries, and distribution of fields remain unspecified. The land becomes a symbol of communal existence, not a complete geographical survey.

Several Historical Levels of Women's Leadership

Ratnā's name belongs to the early record of land rights, Mandākinī's to the educational institution, Sulochanā's to the night assembly, and Champāvatī's to the coordination of the present litigation. The agency of women from four periods converges within this narrative. The work does not say that they share one lineage or identical social standing. Its literary strength lies in the interweaving of distinct roles across time. Condensing them into the deeds of a single emblematic woman would erase this plurality.

The Anonymous Lawyers and the Agency of History

The young lawyers' work is significant, but their names, arguments, and speaking parts in court are absent. Champāvatī occupies the central position of organizer; the advocates appear as a collective professional

resource. The book shows a productive outcome of the educational tradition without offering individual stories of these graduates' professional lives. This distribution of attention makes the heroine prominent while leaving technical expertise in the background.

The Judge's Praise: Narratorial Validation within the Fiction

The judge praises the records as "detailed, consistent, year by year." An official voice inside the fictional court thus recognizes the village's preservation of its own history. Such praise does not establish the real-world historical existence of every figure in the novel's earlier narrative. The judge, too, is a character in the fictional world. His words operate as a device of internal validation, while a critical reader retains the distinction between the novel's institutional testimony and independently demonstrated history.

Compression of Time: From Centuries to a Single Case

The narrative begins with the present revenue survey, returns almost at once to the age of Somar and Ratnā through a document, and then moves back to contemporary litigation and Burhbā's long memory. Several centuries become present through a few written names and registers. This is not a fully enacted flashback with scenes from the past but a compressed historical presence mediated by cultural records. One dispute gathers a long chain of preceding causes into a manageable story.

The Song's Forgiveness and the Prose's Resistance

"The Path of Forgiveness" makes the refusal to ignite the fire of vengeance its decisive action. The prose instead narrates Champāvatī's collection of evidence and a judicial decision; it contains no directly enacted rite of forgiveness. Burhbā's "not retaliation, but justice" agrees with the lyric's ethical intention, while the structure of events remains different. The song represents personal emotional restraint; the prose, collective institutional resistance. They should not be combined into one fabricated episode of Sukhdev's behavior.

Memory Facing the Future: An Ending or Only an Interval?

Burhbā says that no struggle is wasted if its memory remains alive. The sentence makes a present victory meaningful in relation to earlier anguish. It does not establish that new forms of land injustice can never arise. The particular lawsuit has ended successfully, but the underlying inequalities of power have not been demonstrably abolished. The expansive novel's system of cultural memory here produces a hopeful village history without guaranteeing a final resolution of all future conflict.

Gaps in Class and Caste Speech

The leatherworkers' settlement is named as the center of the conflict, but residents' independent explanations, women's individual voices, workers' concerns about housing and fields, and the everyday consequences of victory are not developed. Champāvatī, Burhbā, the landlord, and the judge are the principal interpreters of events. Consequently, the community involved in the land struggle remains partially mediated through others' representation. Acknowledging the collective success does not eliminate the critical obligation to attend to the people who are not heard directly.

The Return on Social Institutions: Narrative Weaving

Haripati's manuscript was a thread of literary creation, Mandākinī's school of education, Yādavānand's shadow register of documentary record, and Sulochanā's night assembly of communal organization. Established separately, they now act together. The extensive prehistory thereby yields a meaningful narrative return. Without such connections, a large-scale work might become merely a catalogue of social entries. This chapter is a particularly strong example of the interdependence of its narrative strands.

Recalling the Limits of the Critical Evidence

The new landlord is not a descendant of the earlier Ugrasen; the song's scene of fire does not occur in the principal prose; a full adversarial court debate is not given; the actual written judgment is not reproduced; independent responses from the leatherworkers are brief; the lawyers remain unnamed; and no verbatim extract from the old register is supplied. These are different kinds of limitation—narratorial compression, divergence between song and prose, and restricted representation of characters. They should be considered alongside the achievement without being reduced to a uniform list of errors.

Overall Judgment and Limits of the Source

"Sukhdev's Revenge" powerfully converts the promise of violent retaliation into a victory achieved through communal documentary capacity. Champāvatī's leadership, the shadow register, Haripati's manuscript, educated lawyers, the women's assembly, and judicial recognition bring centuries of narrative threads to a common outcome. Its principal limits are the absence from the prose of the song's forgiveness scene involving Sukhdev and the compressed plurality of voices among the actual inhabitants of the leatherworkers' quarter. The following chapter, [–63], raises a new problem about the future of memory through the arrival of print technology.

Critical Section 38 | Original Chapter −63 — The First Printed Page

The Prehistory · The arrival of printing, self-conscious narration, incompletion, the postponement of publication, and the dissemination of stories

The Chapter's Textual Boundaries and Narrative Form

According to the original contents, Chapter [−63], "The First Printed Page," begins on page 265 and the following Chapter [−62] on page 269; pages 265–268 are therefore its approximate printed span. The proverb, the print-celebration song "The First Printed Name," the prose account of the decision involving Devakīnandan, Haripati Gangādhar, and Burhbā, and the commentary on printing technology are separate textual levels. The central concern is not simply the marvel of a mechanical device. It is the conflict between fixing a narrative in a single published form and allowing it to continue growing as a living story. Through this question, the novel begins to reflect directly upon its own state of composition.

The preliminary figures belong to the existing assessment and are not an independently established count of events. The principal transitions are the introduction of a printing press, Gangādhar's proposal, Burhbā's advice to wait, a promise extending into the future, and the immediate printing of smaller booklets. The story does not end with the indiscriminate decision to print everything. It differentiates the selected circulation of local knowledge from the deferred publication of the overarching narrative.

The First Page of the Title: What Was Actually Printed?

"The First Printed Page" might initially suggest the publication of the first page of Burhbā's great narrative. But the prose decides against printing that complete work for the time being. Instead, small books on the Coconut-Leaf School, the women's night assembly, and agricultural knowledge are printed. Thus the title marks an initial step into the age of printing rather than the actual publication of Burhbā's immense book. The reversal of expectation is the chapter's dramatic point: a first printed page is not the final certification of a tale, but a technological opportunity with many possible uses.

Permanence in the Opening Proverb: Difficult to Erase, Not Impossible

The opening proverb says, "The first printed page—now it will be difficult to erase a name." The word "difficult" signals an enlarged means of

preserving communal memory; it does not assert absolute indestructibility. Multiple printed copies can travel into different hands, diminishing dependence upon a single manuscript. Yet printing does not guarantee that a name is accurate or that a narrative is complete. The relative restraint of the proverb differs from the song's much more categorical language of imperishability. That difference within the opening material needs to be recorded.

"The First Printed Name": Ink and Iron in the Song

The chhāpā-maṅgal song describes arranging letters of iron, black ink, the movement of the press's handle, and the production of many copies from one line of type. The prose, for its part, marvels that a printing press can produce "hundreds of identical pages in a single day," but does not depict the particular machine, its operators, the composition of its types, or a ceremony held on the day of printing. The song imagines the labor of production; the prose summarizes the machine's social effect. Together they give the technological arrival sensory force, without supplying a technical manual or a documentary history of a particular press.

"Even a Flood Cannot Erase It": The Question of Hyperbole

The lyric declares that a printed name cannot be burned by fire or washed away by water. This is a poetic exaggeration of trust in memory. Books, paper, and ink remain vulnerable to physical damage. The wider novel itself contains an extended background of floods, water, and the loss or peril of books, making the claim of literal indestructibility particularly open to questioning. In the prose, Burhbā worries less about material immortality than about the danger of publishing a story before it has finished growing. The difference between the lyric's confident affirmation and the witness's hesitation is one of the chapter's principal conceptual tensions.

From Champāvatī to Devakīnandan: The Movement of Succession

The prose transfers responsibility for the observance from Champāvatī to her son Devakīnandan. She had succeeded in a struggle over land rights in Chapter [−64]; her successor must consider a fresh opportunity created by printing. The generational transition is compressed into one sentence. Nothing in it specifies the date of Champāvatī's death, Devakīnandan's education, or an exact act of formal appointment. Compression sustains the novel's continuing line of responsibility while leaving the detailed lives of individual generations in the background.

The Distance between Town and Village: The Route of a New Technology

A printing press opens in a town a few kos from the village. This modest geographical separation creates a new route for the circulation of knowledge. The town possesses the machine and the village holds the old stories; Gangādhar moves between them to propose a new possibility. The text does not present the town as wholly modern or the village as immovably archaic. Villagers have already preserved knowledge in writing, and local institutions will put the new technology to use. Tradition and change can therefore cooperate across this spatial arrangement.

Printing in Maithili and Hindi: The Social Reach of Languages

The narrator explicitly says that the new press prints books in both Maithili and Hindi. Within this bilingual environment, the village's cultural knowledge might reach a wider readership. The text does not state the number of books printed, the caste and occupation of their readers, the policies governing language choice, or the historical year when the press was established. It is consequently a literary representation of the introduction of printing into society, not a dated document of Indian printing history. The linguistic possibility is established; the particular distribution of every printed work is not.

Gangādhar: The Double Role of Author and Publisher

Haripati Gangādhar is a young writer-publisher who works in the town and has inherited a secret manuscript from his ancestor. Recognizing the possibilities of the press, he rushes to the village. His enthusiasm is not represented merely as an appetite for personal renown; he wants to preserve and share the old stories more widely. The narrative gives no detailed account of publishing income, commercial contracts, reader markets, or the trajectory of his private career. He represents a new medium within the story rather than the complete social history of printing entrepreneurs.

Haripati Gangādhar as a “Seventh-Generation” Descendant: The Return of a Name

Gangādhar is said to be a seventh-generation descendant of the poet Haripati, and to have been named in his ancestor's honor. Authorship thereby survives as both an activity and an object of genealogical remembrance. But the earlier poet Haripati and the present Haripati Gangādhar are not one person. The recurrence of the name could encourage the reader to merge two ages, although the prose clearly distinguishes them through descent. How the designation “seventh

generation" fits the novel's other immense stretches of time remains uncertain in the absence of a precise chronology.

The Inherited Palm-Leaf Manuscript: The Long Life of an Object

Haripati Gangādhar has inherited his predecessor's secret palm-leaf manuscript. It is said to preserve the stories of Burhbā, Hulāsā, Jīvantī, Sukhdev, and Gaṅgeś and Mālatī. A material manuscript thus returns historical characters to the current decision about printing. The writer, the generations who revised or transmitted it, and its precise number of leaves are not fully specified. Nevertheless, its physical inheritance is an effective resource within the fiction. The book is no longer only a relic; it is a possible source from which many future copies might be made.

"The Complete Story" and "Still Unfinished": The Central Opposition

Gangādhar enthusiastically announces that his ancestor's manuscript contains Burhbā's "complete story." Burhbā responds that names such as Subhāgī, Yaśpati, Padmā, and Rāmsevak are still being added, so the story remains unfinished. Two meanings of completeness are thus in conflict: the currently available account assembled so far, and an unceasing communal narrative extending into a future not yet lived. Those meanings might offer a conditional reconciliation, but the prose unquestionably stages a conflict between an allegedly complete manuscript and an incomplete living history. The postponement of printing derives its artistic justification from that unstable sense of completion.

The Internal Inconsistency between Written and Unwritten

The last part of the prose says that Burhbā's entire story remained "still unwritten, still oral, still alive." Earlier in the very same chapter, however, a secret palm-leaf manuscript already contains many of his stories. If "unwritten" means that no definitive total edition exists, the two statements can be reconciled. If it means that none of the Burhbā narrative has been written, there is a direct contradiction. The main text does not fully clarify which meaning it intends. An exacting criticism should identify the possible distinction between a final comprehensive account and an existing partial written collection without pretending the tension is absent.

Gangādhar's Run: The Dramatic Velocity of Enthusiasm

Seeing the press, Gangādhar "came running" to the village and excitedly calls for Devakīnandan. The sharp movement from town to village, followed by direct speech, quickens the story's pace. A technological development becomes palpable through a character's bodily excitement. The route, travel time, and Gangādhar's conversations with the press's

owner remain undescribed. A brief action captures the emotional moment of change without making the episode a detailed history of an industry.

Devakīnandan as Intermediary: From Information to Deliberation

Devakīnandan hears Gangādhar's proposal and carries the question to Burhbā under the peepal. He is not the final authority on the technology, but the mediator between a young writer's proposal and a communal tradition. After the witness speaks, Gangādhar changes his plan. Three functions are thus distributed among three figures: the advocate of the new medium, the bearer of the question, and the witness to the continuing narrative. Their disagreement results in a shared decision, not a violent confrontation.

Burhbā's Prolonged Silence: A Pause before Decision

On hearing the proposal, Burhbā remains silent "for a long time." The narrator remarks that such silence precedes major decisions. The pause prolongs one dramatic moment within a story otherwise marked by extensive compression of time. The full movement of thought inside the silence is not represented; afterward Burhbā recalls an earlier decision concerning writing. Silence here serves to restrain the pace and signal historical responsibility. It is not independently proven evidence that the character is withholding secret information.

Recalling the Earlier Decision about Language

Burhbā recalls that members of the earlier writer's lineage once asked permission to write the history, and that he insisted upon the everyday language of the village rather than the ornate speech of a royal court. The earlier choice of language and the present choice of medium become stages of one prolonged discussion. First the question was: for whom, and in what language, should the story be written? Now it is: when should it be printed, and in how many copies? Tradition appears not as an inflexible prohibition but as editorial judgment responding to different circumstances.

Subhāgī, Yaśpati, Padmā, and Rāmsevak: A List of Incompletion

Burhbā specifically names Subhāgī, Yaśpati, Padmā, and Rāmsevak among those whose histories continue to enter the larger story. The list is not an abstract argument against closure; it makes incompletion personal. Certain lives remain unsettled, some sorrows require fuller public articulation, and other names acquire new significance within communal institutions. The decision to print is therefore measured against the continuity of human experience rather than only the attractiveness of a finished volume. The present chapter does not expand Subhāgī's earlier particular story.

A Story Still Alive and Taking Root: The Narrative Describes Itself

Burhbā says, "The story is still alive, still growing." On this account, completion becomes a condition that should be met before printing the definitive narrative. The novel turns its own creative process into an event of the fictional world: the story discusses whether it has yet been fully told. Such self-conscious narration draws together author, character, manuscript, and an imagined future readership. Yet the condition generates a further problem. If new names can always be added, who will ever determine the proper moment to close the narrative for publication?

Fear of "Closing" the Story: The Book as Metaphor

Burhbā fears that printing the account immediately will cause it to be "closed in one fixed form." The fear concerns editorial stabilization of meaning more than the physical hardness of the printed object. A particular edition presents itself to readers as a completed form, while the society and the lives it records continue. The book becomes a portrait of one temporal state; living communal narration remains a flow. In reality, printing does not make revised editions or supplements impossible. Burhbā's concern should be read as a character's perception, not as a universal technological fact established by the narrator.

Gangādhar's Initial Disappointment and Changed Intention

At first Gangādhar is disappointed by the reply; then he understands its reasoning and agrees to delay publication. The brief psychological movement changes a publisher's immediate ambition into a promise of long-term inheritance. He does not abandon the project. Rather, he allows for an eventual descendant to publish it. The desire remains while its temporal horizon changes—from immediate printing to preservation over generations. This produces a clear narrative turn from eager proposal to revised commitment.

The Descendants' Promise: Creating a Future Reader

Gangādhar promises that he and his descendants will preserve the manuscript, and that "when the time comes" a future descendant will print it for the world. A character in the present thus imagines readers who do not yet exist. Authorship becomes a task extending beyond one human lifespan. The source specifies neither a test for determining the right time, nor the identity of a descendant, nor the edition that might be produced. This open space creates anticipation for later chapters. The promise is not proof that the projected publication has already taken place.

Partial Printing: Settled Practical Uses beside the Unsettled Great Narrative

Although Burhbā's complete account is deferred, Gangādhar does print the curriculum of the Coconut-Leaf School, the rules of the women's night assembly, and a collection of local agricultural knowledge. The prose represents all three as actually printed. Materials whose immediate communal use is recognizable enter circulation; the still-expanding great narrative is held back. The work thus does not construct a rigid opposition between print and tradition. It chooses media according to the material at issue. A legitimate critical question remains: why is fixing a useful institutional text acceptable while fixing the larger story is considered premature?

The Night Assembly's Rulebook: Oral Institution into Printed Discipline

The Women's Night Assembly was founded in Chapter [−66] as a social institution whose decisions did not possess binding legal authority. In Chapter [−63], its "rulebook" is printed. The link between episodes indicates a movement from an organized public meeting to disseminated written regulations. The earlier chapter does not narrate the composition of a full rulebook, and the present one does not reproduce its articles. No particular procedural provision of women's justice may therefore be supplied from imagination. The story demonstrates the circulation of institutional knowledge, not the contents of a complete legal code.

Printing Agricultural Knowledge: A New Medium for Marginalized Experience

Gangādhar also prints a collection of the village's agricultural knowledge. Printing consequently extends beyond philosophy, literature, and judicial assemblies to farmers' practical experience. We are not told what part farmers took in the decision to print, who edited their knowledge, or in which dialect or language the field experience was recorded. The possibility of giving public standing to local knowledge is considerable. Yet how fully the voices of those who perform agricultural labor survived on the printed page remains unanswered.

The School Curriculum: The Social Reproduction of Education

Printing the Coconut-Leaf School's curriculum means that teaching can become something more than lessons passed directly from teacher to pupil. A text reproduced in many copies may circulate across a greater distance. The press's technological ability to generate hundreds of copies, however, is distinct from evidence that hundreds of copies of this particular

curriculum were produced. Nor do we know how many schools used it, which castes of pupils gained access, or precisely what subjects the curriculum contained. The narrative represents a change of medium rather than a comprehensive survey of education.

Leaf, Palm Leaf, Paper, and Printed Page: A Sequence of Media

The names preserved upon coconut leaves, Haripati's secret palm-leaf manuscript, the notebook called the shadow register, and the printed page are successive material bearers of memory in the novel. A new instrument does not necessarily obliterate the older means; it introduces new possibilities for redistribution. This long sequence of objects gains literary force when their uses change and interact rather than appearing as a mere inventory. Gangādhar's inherited palm-leaf manuscript remains a potential source for printing, while the educational and practical materials have already entered print.

Print's Permanence and the Manuscript's Vulnerability: Three Perspectives

The song proclaims that no fire or flood can erase a printed name. Gangādhar, in the prose, regards multiple copies as a means of reducing the danger of loss. Burhbā fears a fixed, incomplete edition more than he values this enhanced circulation. Three perspectives are therefore placed upon the same technology: the folk song's faith in imperishability, the publisher's enthusiasm for preservation, and the witness's anxiety about a developing story. Their coexistence is a notable literary achievement. None of the voices should automatically be promoted into the uncontested technological truth of the entire work.

Limits of the Rigid Opposition between Orality and Writing

The concluding prose describes the account as “unwritten, oral, alive,” even though palm-leaf manuscripts, registers, and other writings already exist within the world of the story. Orality and writing are therefore not wholly separate in the literal sense. The text may intend that no complete, authorized, final version has been written. “Oral” would then evoke the continuing retelling of the community. Yet the prose does not fully spell out this distinction. The critic must retain the tension: the literary formulation is categorical, while the material situation of the narrative is mixed.

The Cultural World of Maithili and Its Relation to Languages of Wider Authority

The press produces books in Maithili and Hindi. Earlier, Burhbā had insisted upon village speech rather than the embellished language of a

royal court. Read together, the two details reveal a movement in the question of linguistic value: whose language makes cultural memory accessible, and to which readers? The chapter does not state the precise distribution of languages among the published curricula and other works, nor does it expand on Gangādhar's particular language choice. The aspiration toward linguistic recognition is legible, but the bilingual form of every single published book is not established.

A Paratextual Future: The Work Dreams of Its Own Publication

The post-chapter commentary treats Burhbā's postponement of printing as a distant prefiguration of the novel's eventual real-world publication. This is authorial self-reference, not direct knowledge possessed by Gangādhar in the earlier fictional period. A future reader may hold the published novel while reading within it of a decision that its own story should remain unpublished. The resulting irony—the published work narrating the reasons for its nonpublication—creates a self-conscious structure. But identifying that literary device is different from verifying the actual chronology of the book's external publication.

The Aesthetics of Incompletion and Editorial Authority

Burhbā's refusal depends on the claim that the story must remain alive. Yet who has the cultural authority to say when it is complete: Burhbā, the lineage of writers, the village assembly, or future readers? Within the dialogue Burhbā's judgment is decisive and Gangādhar accepts it. The separate voices of narrators and recorders receive less space. Incompletion may carry artistic value, but indefinite postponement can also become an exclusive power over the history of writing. The novel does not stage a fully developed public debate about this question of authority.

The Invisibility of Printing Labor

The song evokes setting type, applying ink, and turning the machine, but the prose gives no individual account of press workers, typesetters, papermakers, or the social situation of printers. The visible enthusiasm belongs chiefly to the writer-publisher Gangādhar, while material production is compressed into a collective technological result. Printing thus becomes an object of literary wonder more than a narrative of workers' lives. For a social history of media, this is a significant gap in representation.

The Rhythm of Scene, Summary, and Dialogue

The establishment of the press is narrated in summary. Gangādhar's return to the village becomes a swift scene; Devakīnandan's consultation provides the transition; Burhbā's silence and extended reply give the central

deliberation greater duration; Gangādhar's promise condenses a psychological change; and the printing of shorter works returns the narrative to summary. Through this rhythm, a technological event becomes a drama of judgment. The story spends more time on its self-reflexive decision than on a scene of printing labor.

Principal Inconsistencies and a Brief Assessment

The folk song's assertion that a printed name is indestructible by fire and water contradicts the vulnerability of physical books. Gangādhar's "complete story" and Burhbā's "unfinished" account expose differing senses of completeness. The existence of a written palm-leaf manuscript sits uneasily beside the final description of the story as "unwritten." The main narrative is deferred while curricula, women's assembly regulations, and agricultural knowledge are printed: this last difference is selective dissemination, not necessarily a contradiction. No definite historical date is provided for the press. Taken together, these features make the chapter self-consciously literary, but some of its confident statements about technical permanence require caution.

Overall Narrative Judgment and the Source's Limits

The central achievement of "The First Printed Page" is to turn a printing press into an instrument through which the work questions its own unfinished condition. Gangādhar's urgent enthusiasm, Burhbā's silence, the sense of an incomplete communal account, the descendants' pledge, and the production of useful smaller books give simultaneous force to the choices to print and to postpone. Its limitations include an exaggerated fear that publication necessarily closes a story, the ambiguous opposition between "complete" and "unwritten," the song's rhetoric of indestructibility, and the lack of direct attention to workers at the press. The following chapter, [–62], "Waiting for Relief," opens a different crisis of time and collective action.

Critical Section 39 | Original Chapter −62 — Waiting for Relief

The Prehistory · The duration of famine, the remoteness of relief, a collective protagonist, and the new function of a site of remembrance

Introduction to the Text and the Chapter's Narrative Axis

"Waiting for Relief" tells of a village organizing itself under Sāvitrī Devī's leadership during a famine. The opening proverb, the famine song "Waiting on the Road," the main prose narrative, and the subsequent commentary on colonial famine policy are four distinct textual levels. The central sequence is the village's day-to-day effort to survive between the announcement of government relief and its arrival three months later. The narrative does not reject assistance from the government; it rejects the alternative of remaining inactive while waiting for that assistance.

The earlier figures are precomputed figures, not a fresh independent count of events or their density. The failure of rainfall for a year, the governmental plan, the common granary, the daily kitchen, and the three-month delay are compressed into short paragraphs. Against this temporal breadth, the more closely presented scenes are the dialogue between Sāvitrī Devī and Burhbā and the final exchange with the relief officer.

From Failed Rainfall to a Picture of Famine

The narrator establishes the crisis through a sequence of images: the rains fail completely, fields crack, grain stores stand empty, and hunger arrives at the door. Cracks in the soil constitute the environmental image; the empty household granary signifies domestic insecurity. The personification of "hunger standing at the door" does not introduce an additional character. The narrative supplies neither the kinds of crops nor the calendar year nor household-by-household grain figures. Its opening is a concentrated rendering of collective experience, not an agricultural survey.

Sāvitrī Devī's Entrance: Name and Succession

Sāvitrī Devī, Devakīnandan's daughter, becomes the new successor responsible for the cultural observance. Her name, we are told, commemorates the earlier Sāvitrī, creating a familial pattern of returning names. No particular date is given for Devakīnandan's death or for the transfer of responsibility. Sāvitrī Devī acquires an independent identity by asking questions, devising a plan, and answering the official in a crisis. She is more than a passive bearer of hereditary duty.

The Relief Plan: Announced Assistance and an Unreceived Result

The government announces grain distribution, food in exchange for work, and medical aid. Yet the nearest relief centre is twenty kos away and registration is complicated. The gap between a formal announcement and the immediate needs of hungry bodies becomes the chapter's central contradiction. The officer's name, the language of application forms, and individual registration hearings are not provided. Institutional distance is conveyed in narratorial summary. This generates tension without identifying a particular official's misconduct.

The Geography of Twenty *Kos*

The relief centre's distance of "twenty kos" is a decisive geographical datum within the story. Help may exist at the nearest point on the administrative map and nevertheless remain beyond the practical reach of hungry households. The route, means of transport, duration of travel, and fare are not specified. The distance functions literarily by extending waiting time and linking bureaucratic procedure to bodily hardship. It does not establish that every village's relief centre lay equally far away.

The Story of Registration: Procedure as an Obstacle

The account that many families weakened before they could finish registering is a compressed and extreme expression of institutional delay. The story does not dramatize each governmental regulation; it offers the information that the procedure was complex. As a result, the focus falls on an impersonal system rather than the malicious conduct of a named officer. The artistic advantage of this compression is that famine remains an immediate crisis. Its limitation is the absence of diverse voices from within administrative life.

Sukhdev and Bholā: The Return of Earlier Waiting

Burhbā reminds Sāvitrī Devī of Sukhdev Mahto and Bholā: the former lost his life while waiting for his turn under the timing-device arrangement, while the latter lost years to successive court dates. These incidents, belonging to separate periods, now become recurring images of the unjust institutional use of time. Sukhdev's death, Bholā's wasted years, and the present hunger of children are not the same event. Burhbā uses them as distinct exempla with which to interpret the new ethical situation.

The Metaphor of Waiting and Actual Hunger

Burhbā's formulation connecting "waiting" with "death" intensifies the threatened crisis. Yet the story finally declares that the famine caused no loss of life in the village. It is therefore essential to distinguish the metaphor of death through waiting from the number of deaths actually

narrated. The fear of prolonged waiting changes Sāvitrī Devī's decision immediately; the metaphor itself does not amount to a depicted death.

"Today" versus "On Its Way": Tense and Urgency in the Dialogue

Sāvitrī Devī tells Burhbā that government assistance is "on its way," whereas the children are hungry "today." These two temporal positions embody the chapter's argument: promised relief in the future confronts present need. The necessity for action is expressed by the character herself, not merely imposed by an external narrator. The dialogue is the pivot that moves the story from collective apprehension and inactivity toward organized action.

A New Function for the Women's Night Assembly

Sāvitrī Devī draws on the experience of the women's night assembly in devising an emergency plan. In Chapter [–66], this institution arose to hear domestic violence and other questions of justice; here it coordinates food distribution. Such a recurrence turns the institution into a living resource of the plot rather than a name mentioned solely for continuity. The number of meetings held and the quantity of grain distributed by individual women are not stated. The narrator represents the assembly as an aggregate social capacity.

The Common Grain Store: A Change in the Relations of Things and People

Families contribute grain to a common store according to their capacity. Grain thereby travels, in the narrative, from the private household container to a system of collective distribution. The numbers of families able to contribute only a little, the possibility of resistance, and discussions resolving unequal resources are not narrated. The story opts for the unifying summary "every family." The result is a powerful impression of a community gathering itself together, accompanied by the reduced visibility of distinct household experiences.

The School's Young People: From Calculation to Sustenance

Young people educated at the Coconut-Leaf School calculate the grain required in each household and organize equitable distribution. The earlier history of literacy and schooling thus enters the present task of preserving life. These young people remain unnamed, and their daily disputes or the figures in their calculations are not reproduced. The narrative gives earlier social knowledge a practical use while omitting a day-by-day depiction of the distribution process.

The Channā Grove: From Memorial Wood to Kitchen

The common kitchens are established around the Channā Grove. Chapter [–70] made this place a memorial to the dead and the living; now it becomes a place where hungry people receive food. The reuse of space connects the community's cultural inheritance to the immediate needs of living bodies. The story does not describe the hearths, the division of work among women and men, or the arrangements for fuel. A symbolic centre acquires a practical function.

The Frequency of "Every Day": Three Months in Summary

The prose says that, every day, even when grain was scarce, everyone received something. A single statement incorporates many days of activity: the narration presents a repeated ideal rather than hundreds of separate scenes over three months. Its daily rhythm evokes the endurance required to withstand a lasting emergency. The actual quantities of grain and the differences of feeling between households remain unstated.

Sonmā Māzhin's Descendants and the Remaining Water of the Kamalā-Balān

Descendants of Sonmā Māzhin teach a new method of catching fish in a stretch of the Kamalā-Balān River where some water survives. Local knowledge from the preceding stories of ponds and rivers thus becomes an answer to the initial helplessness of famine. The river is not an inert background: its remaining water sustains a possibility of food. Yet the volume of water, species of fish, number of fishers, and precise means of distribution are unspecified. The descendants have no individual names; their work is recognized through their ancestor's name. The usefulness of their labour is plain, but their independent voices are limited.

Ratnā's Descendants: From Medicinal Plants to Roots and Tubers

Ratnā's descendants identify wild roots and tubers considered edible. Earlier accumulated botanical experience associated with women takes on a new function in the emergency. A family's tradition of knowledge about medicinal plants and the present knowledge of food-bearing tubers are not identical, though both concern plants. Which tubers are safe, which forest supplies them, and how many children eat them are not explained. The story presents a general possibility of survival; it is not an instructional manual for collecting food. Maintaining that distinction is necessary to a faithful reading.

Grain, Fish, and Tubers: Three Sources of Food

The shared store of grain, fish from the Kamalā-Balān, and wild roots and tubers constitute three sources of food. The narrator does not supply a single miraculous solution, but represents survival as the combined use of multiple resources. These three kinds of food also bring together previously separate strands of occupation, gender, and place. How these sources could sustain the entire village nutritionally for three months is not investigated in terms of quantities or seasons. The dramatic result is concentrated; the economics of production and distribution remains condensed.

The Unnamed Labour of the Common Kitchen

The prose says that the villagers establish communal kitchens but does not identify the individual cooks, the work of obtaining firewood, carrying water, or cleaning utensils. The organizational work of the women's night assembly is mentioned, but it does not follow that every task in the kitchens is explicitly assigned to women. Collective action is a genuine social achievement in the text; at the same time, the many bodies and daily exertions within that summary remain obscure. Narratologically, the difference between the unified protagonist called "the village" and the unnamed people performing its tasks is significant.

"Every Family in the Village": The Scope of the Collective Character

"Every family" contributes and the needs of "every household" are calculated. This inclusive language shapes the village into a collective character. It does not separately portray the number of landless families, elderly people, widows, or migrants in each settlement. The story makes unity its central line of composition rather than unfolding the conflicts generated by unequal resources. Its assertion of comprehensive inclusion should not be treated as a census. The literary effect is collective courage; the representational limit is the scarcity of distinct voices.

The Government Team Arrives Three Months Later: A Reversal of Roles

"Finally, after three months," a government team reaches the village and is astonished to find its people alive. At the beginning, the administration appears to be the powerful helper and the village the helpless recipient waiting for it. At the end, the administration becomes a surprised observer and the village an active organizer. The reversal carries an element of dramatic irony. Yet the prose does not say whether the officers ultimately distribute the grain or provide medical services. Nor does the village refuse

governmental help. The reversal concerns the characters' positions, not a fully narrated resolution of relief policy.

No Death from Famine: The Narrator's Definitive Statement

The original story explicitly declares that "no life was lost to the famine" in the village. This is a narratorial result and presents an ideal achievement of collective action. Other consequences—illness, displacement, and injuries to health—are not independently assessed. "No one died of famine" must not be expanded into the claim that no person died from any cause during the three months. Emotionally, the sentence marks the story's highest point of victory, compressing the outcome of collective effort into one assertion.

"Great Loss" in Neighbouring Villages: Comparison and Silence

The narrator states that neighbouring villages, while waiting for government relief, suffered heavy losses. Their names, available resources, death counts, and local circumstances are not supplied. The comparison is used to highlight the readiness of Gaṛh Nārikel. It does not establish that every other community was uniformly inactive. Why help was not sought across villages, and whether poverty or distance was comparable, remain unanswered. The unequal detail given to achievement and comparison must be identified as a literary choice.

The Official's Question: An Altered Institutional View

The relief officer asks, "How did you manage this without our help?" His question registers surprise and unfamiliarity with the community's capacity. In reply Sāvitrī Devī neither repudiates government assistance nor represents herself as a miraculous rescuer. The dialogue places two ways of seeing beside each other: an external authority is astonished by the living outcome, while local leadership describes the cooperative practices responsible for it. The text says nothing about whether the official subsequently changes policy.

Sāvitrī Devī's Answer: A Response to the Presumption of Helplessness

"We did not refuse your assistance," Sāvitrī Devī says. This formulation prevents the story from becoming a rigid doctrine of solitary self-sufficiency. What she rejects is the assumption that, without the government, the village must simply regard itself as helpless and sit waiting. The possibility of cooperation remains open even as passive dependency is refused. The narrative does not detail what happened when the promised relief finally arrived, but her words redefine the relation

between the local community and an institution of authority. Hers is a consequential character voice, not merely an appended moral slogan.

Burhbā's Final Voice: Witness versus Agent

Burhbā distinguishes his own duty—"I preserve names"—from the need for human beings to act if they are to survive. The supernatural guardian of memory acknowledges a limit to his power. In earlier emergencies, too, practical action belonged primarily to people. During the famine he does not produce grain or oversee its material distribution. He interprets the lesson; Sāvitrī Devī and the numerous households perform the work. This division of roles is consistent with the novel's long narrative of collective heroism.

"Even Hungry Stomachs Smiled": The Song's Generalized Joy

The folk song "Waiting on the Road" depicts hungry stomachs smiling once grain is shared. In the prose, however, the village experiences three months of fear, hunger, and small rations. There is no direct scene establishing that everyone was happy or that the fear of hunger disappeared. The lyric's hope expresses social companionship, while the prose presents the material practice of rationing. Their tonal work differs. The song's own image of dwindling grain and fragile hope maintains the sorrowful background against which even limited joy can be heard.

Narrative Time and Frequency: One Year, Three Months, Every Day

The chapter brings together a year of failed rainfall, a three-month delay in government relief, and the repeated daily work of the common kitchens. The narrator accommodates these three temporal layers within a short text. Extended scenes are scarce; summary supplies the principal movement. The phrase "every day" evokes the durability of the undertaking without recounting separate meals and experiences on each day. The chapter succeeds in creating an awareness of daily effort, not in providing an exhaustive chronology.

Overall Evaluation: The Collective Protagonist's Victory and Its Limits

The chapter's effective narrative design combines the distance of the state, the immediate hunger of children, and the coordinated action of many institutions established earlier in the novel. Sāvitrī Devī stands at the centre, but heroism is collective. Sonmā's river knowledge, Ratnā's botanical knowledge, calculations made possible by the school, the organizational work of the night assembly, and kitchens at the memorial grove turn earlier narrative resources into practical instruments. Its weaknesses are the imprecise division of labour, the one-sided representation of neighbouring villages, the thin material account of

survival over three months, and the open question of what followed the arrival of official assistance.

Sources and the Next Narrative Connection

The textual basis is Chapter [–62], "Waiting for Relief," in Volume 0 of the original trilogy, including "Waiting on the Road," the prose exchanges involving Sāvitrī Devī, Burhbā, and the official, and the post-chapter commentary. The chapter explicitly situates its fictional world under British rule, but gives no documentary historical year or district for this famine. The next chapter, [–61], "The Comet in the Sky," changes the narrative tone through an unusual celestial sight and an anticipation of future disasters.

Critical Section 40 | Original Chapter −61 — The Comet in the Sky

The Prehistory · A sight in the sky, collective fear, apprehension, foreshadowing, and levels of narration

The Chapter's Form: From an External Sight to Inner Apprehension

In "The Comet in the Sky," an unusual astronomical sight frightens the village during Rudranāth's period of responsibility. The opening proverb, the sky-song "Star and Earth," the prose dialogue between Rudranāth and Burhbā, and the commentary that follows are distinct textual levels. The chapter contains no actual scene of a dream, although it does contain unsettled feelings, apprehensions, and images of the future. Its chain of events is limited: the comet appears; an astrologer issues a frightening prediction; Burhbā gives a qualified answer; the village adopts precautions; the comet disappears; and Burhbā remains troubled in solitude.

The primary chapter depicts no one waking from sleep or a dream. Consequently, any question raised in the preliminary plan about dreams can only be applied to the surrounding matters of fear, anticipation, and imagined disaster. A dream scene not written in the source must not be supplied. Identifying this discrepancy between the plan and the text is itself a condition of narratological investigation.

From Sāvitrī Devī to Rudranāth: A Generational Transition

After Sāvitrī Devī, her son Rudranāth assumes responsibility for the observance. The preceding famine chapter gave Sāvitrī Devī an active role in collective leadership; the present story follows Rudranāth as he asks Burhbā how to guide a frightened community in the face of an uncertain sight. The narrative specifies neither the day of transfer nor his mother's death nor the intervening years. "After" establishes a succession of generations, not the exact hour of an event. The compression allows the larger narrative to move directly to a new collective crisis.

An Autumn Night: Establishing a Particular Atmosphere

The prose introduces an exceptionally bright, long-tailed celestial object appearing "one autumn night." The spacious sky and the apparent stillness of the night make the unusual sight more striking. No precise historical year or scientific designation is supplied. "Autumn" is not merely atmospheric decoration: its sequence must later be compared with the burning summer night of Jyeṣṭha in Chapter [−60]. At this moment, readers know only that the sight is unusual; the characters attribute an ominous meaning to it.

The Comet's Three Weeks: Many Nights in One Sentence

Night after night the comet appears to shift from one part of the sky to another before vanishing after three weeks. The narrator compresses many observations through a statement of frequency. There is no separate list of its movement on particular nights or the people who observed it. This compression turns a single unusual phenomenon into the sustained occasion for a collective state of mind. The slow apparent movement of the celestial body contrasts with the speed at which fear spreads through the village.

The Astrologer's Declaration and Collective Fear

An unnamed "elderly astrologer" shouts that the comet foretells a king's death, war, famine, or an epidemic. Neither the astrologer's name nor a passage from an ancient text is furnished. His voice represents a powerful interpretation within popular belief, not an established and universally accepted account. "The villagers" become afraid, but their individual emotions are not narrated independently. Through this loud, anonymous figure the story makes fear itself a socially transmitted event. His proclamation does not predict one specific disaster: it opens a long list of possibilities.

The Wise Elder of the Song and the Astrologer of the Prose

In the folk song, the words "the wise elder said misfortune would come" present a shared report; the prose gives an elderly astrologer a more specific speaking part. It does not explicitly establish that the song's "wise elder" and the prose's "astrologer" are the same person. The song gathers communal apprehension into one voice, while the prose locates the spread of fear in a particular figure. It would be unwarranted to manufacture a complete identity or performance history for either from that difference between media.

Rudranāth's Question about Seeing Beyond Time

Rudranāth asks Burhbā what the comet means, given that the witness's vision can reach "beyond time." The successor expects comprehensive knowledge from Burhbā. The narrative immediately qualifies this expectation, for Burhbā's answer acknowledges the uncertainty of what he perceives. A dramatic question thus arises: does an exceptionally long-lived witness know the future with certainty? At this point the reader's expectation moves alongside Rudranāth's anxiety.

Burhbā's Long Look at the Sky: The Dramatic Duration of Silence

Burhbā gazes at the sky for "a long time" before speaking slowly. The pause expands the duration of a scene amid a narrative otherwise rich in

summary. The narrator does not display any specific divine picture within the act of looking. Burhbā describes his sight as "sometimes clear, sometimes lost in mist." His silence prepares an admission of limited perception rather than a proclamation of supernatural omniscience.

An Indistinct Fear: The Difference between Sight and Experience

Burhbā says that he feels an "indistinct fear" and senses the approach of a difficult period. This is not a clearly depicted future event, date, or sequence of disasters. The language of the narrator and the character retains the openness of a comparison or impression. To the reader, the guardian's private unease becomes foreshadowing, but the character does not know exact future numbers and occurrences. That distance is crucial to understanding the chapter's construction of expectation.

The Star Itself Is Not Responsible: An Interpretative Turn

Burhbā explicitly declares that the celestial body is unaware of human fortunes and moves according to its own laws: it will not bring the impending calamity. His answer displaces the astrologer's ominous causal association without dismissing the possibility of danger. The story shifts attention from a heavenly object as the supposed cause of fear toward the vulnerability of earthly life. The comet acts as a narrative sign; it does not itself produce a fire or an epidemic.

The Double Meaning of a "Sign": Not Cause but Narrative Indication

Burhbā calls the comet "only a sign" that people should be careful. If it is not the agent of disaster, this role as a sign can be understood at two levels: the character's uncertain feeling and the narrator's advance cue to readers about later events. These should not be conflated. The reader may encounter a fire in the subsequent section, but the people of the present chapter do not thereby acquire precise advance knowledge. A subsequent calamity does not retrospectively establish the comet as its material cause.

A Triad of Threats: Water, Fire, and Disease

Burhbā mentions the possible forms "water, fire, or disease." In his final whisper these three images of danger return together. Their repetition creates the expectation of a sequence of catastrophes extending beyond a single event. Yet the present chapter directly depicts neither a spreading fire, a flood, nor a new epidemic. They remain possibilities for the narrative to come. A thematic announcement must be kept separate from an event actually occurring within this chapter.

Rudranāth's Communal Instructions: Fear Turned into Practice

Following Burhbā's answer, Rudranāth instructs every quarter to protect its food stores, keep water sources clean, and report signs of illness immediately. The narrative moves from the astrologer's fearful cry to practical preparedness. What each quarter actually does and what the inspection or precautions accomplish are not described. The issuing of instructions is an event within the chapter; demonstrable success in averting a later catastrophe is not yet shown.

"Not an Useless Effort": A Narrator Looking Back

Of Rudranāth's preparations the narrator observes that, "as became clear later, these were not useless efforts." At this point the narrative voice knows something of events still future to the characters. The retrospective hint leads readers to anticipate a serious crisis. How much Rudranāth himself knows at the time is a separate question. This brief intervention by a narrator with an extensive temporal horizon increases the tension at the end of the episode.

"Invisible Cloud, Fire, Water": From Visible Object to Suggestion

After the comet vanishes, the air over the village feels heavy, "as though" an invisible cloud, invisible fire, and invisible water hover above it. These are not three materially present phenomena directly seen at once. The very word "invisible" marks their absence from sight. Through simile, the atmosphere becomes a place crowded with anticipation. The temporal movement of the composition passes from a celestial object's visible presence to a possible disaster's psychological presence after that object has gone.

Burhbā Moving through the Channā Grove: The Return of an Earlier Memory

Burhbā moves through the Channā Grove as though touching each tree, submerged in anxious reflection. In Chapter [–70], the grove became an extension of his being. Here its many trees offer a familiar point of attachment in a time of fear, but their roots provide no certain answer about the future. The reappearance of this site joins the guardian's memory to an approaching threat. The grove is no mere list of commemorated names; it is a place charged with emotional and supernatural sensation.

"If That Word Is Appropriate": The Narrator Corrects Himself

When describing Burhbā's apparent touching of the trees, the narrator pauses in parentheses to ask whether "touch" is an appropriate word for a being whose own contact is shadowlike. This is a self-conscious moment of

narration rather than ordinary description. The difficulty of expressing a supernatural figure's experience through human verbs is laid before the reader. We should not interpret "touch" as necessarily the unequivocal contact of a physical human hand. The narrator explicitly invites a more figurative understanding.

An Intimate Address to the "Original Crocodile": No Answering Voice

At night Burhbā whispers to the "Original Crocodile," asking whether it too can feel the burden. The present chapter provides no reply, no voice of the crocodile, and no response of the water. The solitary address deepens the guardian's intimate anxiety: apart from the communal assembly, he turns to an entity whose immediate reaction is absent from the account. Readers experience this silence as mystery, but the crocodile's agreement cannot be presumed.

Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sukhdev: History Returns as Apprehension

Burhbā associates the threatened new cycle with the experiences of Hulāsā, Jīvantī, and Sukhdev. Names belonging to distinct earlier tragedies re-enter the narrative as images of future fear. This recollection stimulates the reader's memory while giving shape to a danger not yet known. Yet his language includes both the intensity of "just as before" and the qualification "perhaps." The passage therefore does not establish with certainty that history will reproduce itself in every detail.

Two Voices of Fear: The Astrologer and Burhbā

The astrologer announces assured misfortune in a shouting public voice. Burhbā speaks slowly, admitting uncertainty, and eventually whispers in private. Both address the future, but their narrative styles differ: one makes a public proclamation; the other offers a reflective reply and a solitary final question. These competing interpretations of the same sight alter the reader's expectations. The narrative grants Burhbā greater credibility while retaining the uncertainty of his supposed foresight.

"The Village in Its Place" in the Folk Song: The Irony of Later Disruption

The song emphasizes the village's permanence in contrast to the comet's passage. Yet the prose ends by anticipating cycles of fire, water, and disease, and the next chapter describes houses burning. The village remaining "in its place" may refer to geographical and social continuity, not an assertion that every physical house survives unharmed. The contrast between the lyric's hopeful permanence and the prose's uncertain future sharpens the narrative tension. The cultural survival of names is not identical to the indestructibility of material surroundings.

Stars "Breaking and Joining": The Song versus the Visible Event

The lyric imagines stars "breaking and joining"; the prose describes one bright object with a long tail, moving gradually and disappearing after three weeks. It depicts neither actual fragmentation nor reassembly. This is the difference between a generalized poetic image of the heavens and the much narrower event narrated in prose. The song's action invigorates its imagery but does not add verified incidents to the main narrative.

Brief Radiance versus Enduring Soil: Two Measures of Time

The folk song contrasts the temporary brightness of the sky with names enduring in association with the earth. The prose keeps the comet in view for three weeks and then opens toward a longer history of possible calamities. The short time of a celestial apparition and the intergenerational time of communal memory become contrasting measures. Three weeks are not literally the same as a momentary flash; the song's brevity is relative to the larger temporal horizon. The chapter's rhythm emerges from this disparity between short and long time.

The Movement of Vision from Sky to Earth

At first readers look upward toward the comet. Attention then shifts to the astrologer's words about the future, Burhbā's warning of earthly water, fire, and disease, and finally the roots of the grove. This directional movement brings the narrative back from a lofty spectacle toward risks to local life. The song repeatedly contrasts "above" and "below." The direction of the gaze therefore structures meaning: the sky is the place of wonder and contagious fear; the earth is the place of action and memory.

From Autumn to Jyeṣṭha: A Chronological Inconsistency in the Next Chapter

Chapter [–61] places the comet's appearance on "an autumn night" and gives it a duration of three weeks. The parenthetical introduction to Chapter [–60] then dates the fire "one month after" the comet vanished, although that chapter's prose situates it on a fiercely hot night in Jyeṣṭha. Under the ordinary succession of seasons, three weeks in autumn followed by one more month do not lead to Jyeṣṭha. This is an evident problem in the joining of the two chapters. The text introduces no additional interval of several years or other event that would resolve it. The analysis records the discrepancy rather than inventing a time jump.

Three Weeks, One Month, and a Generational Transfer: A Second Gap

In Chapter [−61], Sāvitrī Devī's son Rudranāth is responsible for the observance. In Chapter [−60], the account of the fire said to occur a month after the comet's disappearance calls Rudranāth's daughter Indrāṇī "now the guardian of the observance." A transfer between generations within such a short stated interval is not inherently impossible, but neither its cause nor its enactment is narrated. Alongside the autumn–Jyeṣṭha discrepancy, this is another chronological gap that weakens the stitching of the episodes. It must be identified separately rather than repaired by assuming an unmentioned decade.

Foreshadowing and the Play of Possible Futures

The narrator repeatedly points to earlier and later events. The astrologer's proclamation of misfortune, Burhbā's three possible disasters, and the retrospective expression "as became clear later" all face toward the future, although they do so from different positions of knowledge. What readers are led to anticipate derives substantially from the narrator's statements, not from any character's perfectly informed foresight. The chapter functions as foreshadowing whose partial fulfilment comes with the subsequent fire. Its strength is the concentration of anticipation; its limitation is that overt advance notices can reduce uncertainty.

Overall Narrative Judgment

With relatively few events, "The Comet in the Sky" brings together an unusual sight, collective fear, rival interpretations, practical precautions, and the anticipation of three kinds of crisis. The narrator's self-correction, Burhbā's qualified speech, his solitary address to the Original Crocodile, and the return to the Channā Grove are particularly effective. The chapter contains no dream scene, however, some statements in the celestial song are poetic exaggerations, and the transition to the next chapter exposes inconsistencies of season and succession. It is an effective prelude to the coming catastrophe rather than a self-contained story that resolves its principal threat.

Source Limits and Reading the Next Chapter

The primary basis is Chapter [−61], "The Comet in the Sky," including "Star and Earth," the dialogue between Rudranāth and Burhbā, and the subsequent commentary on celestial signs. The character's apprehensions are kept distinct from the narrator's reader-directed intimations of later events. In Chapter [−60], "The Night of Fire," the first of the three threatened kinds of crisis becomes an actual occurrence. Its cause, the

villagers' actions, and the lyric's references to death require particular examination.

Critical Section 41 | Original Chapter −60 — The Night of Fire

The Prehistory · The spread of fire, Indrāṇī's perspective, the geography of the pond and grove, and collective action during the night

Establishing the Chapter: From Anticipated Calamity to Actual Fire

"The Night of Fire" changes the apprehension created by the preceding comet episode into a directly experienced disaster. Its proverb, the folk song "New Fire from Ashes," the prose account of the villagers' fire-fighting under Indrāṇī and Burhbā, and the subsequent commentary on cooperation in emergencies are distinct textual levels. The narrative moves through the fire's origin and spread, the danger to the Channā Grove, a human chain carrying water from the pond, the outcome at dawn, and the reconstruction of houses. From the beginning, the main task is not merely to save dwellings, but also to safeguard the grove that serves as the centre of longstanding communal memory.

The earlier numerical indicators are not an independent fresh count of events. In the original prose, a lamp, dry straw, wind, trees, the pond, and human hands affect one another throughout. Accordingly, the event is not exhausted by the statement that "a fire broke out." Its sequence includes danger at night, warning cries, failed initial attempts, organized action, the slowing of the flames near the grove, their extinguishing toward dawn, and subsequent rebuilding.

The Cause of the Fire: Lamp, Straw, and Strong Wind

A gust of wind knocks a lamp near a grain store onto dry straw. Flames erupt immediately, and a strong wind carries them through neighbouring houses and quarters. The prose describes an interaction between objects placed by people and meteorological conditions. The origin of the fire cannot therefore be attributed solely to the "wrath of nature": the position of the lamp and the presence of dry straw also matter. The final communal lesson stresses nature's tremendous power, but the initial causal chain is mixed. A critical reading must preserve both the specific accident and the later moral generalization.

A Night in Jyeṣṭha: The Conflict of Seasons

The main prose places the fire on "a fiercely hot night in Jyeṣṭha," whereas Chapter [−61] situates the comet in autumn, keeps it visible for three weeks, and the introduction to [−60] says the fire follows one month after its disappearance. This constitutes an unmistakable inconsistency in narrative time. The text introduces no leap to another year, special

calendar adjustment, or second comet. If several years are presumed, the stated "one month" is contradicted; if that month is preserved, the movement from autumn to Jyeṣṭha is untenable.

Indrāṇī, Rudranāth's Daughter: Leadership Begins in Crisis

The prose introduces Rudranāth's daughter Indrāṇī as "now the guardian of the observance." In the preceding chapter, Rudranāth held that position; no account explains its transfer within the proposed interval of one month. Nevertheless, within the present episode Indrāṇī is the first person to issue a direct warning of the flames and the organizer of a collective response involving water. Her character emerges through energetic action in the emergency, not simply through an entry in a genealogy. This new scene of women's leadership is, for the moment, centred upon one particular disaster.

The First Glimpse through a Window: A Narrowing of Focalization

Indrāṇī sees the red glow of fire through a window and cries, "Fire! Fire!" At that instant the narrator's wide view of the village narrows to a view from one house. The reader experiences the initial shock through Indrāṇī's perception. She fears the destruction of the whole village, although the outcome is still unknown. "The entire village will burn" is her frightened anticipation, not a statement that the entire settlement is subsequently consumed. The scene moves immediately into her running and knocking on doors.

Running to Knock on Doors: The Spread of Warning

Indrāṇī runs to knock on "every door" in the village. The comprehensive word "every" is a narratorial expression of collective scope, not an inventory of houses individually counted in the prose. Yet an initial individual warning becomes a social sound. The flames move from quarter to quarter, while the alarm also travels from door to door. These are two competing rates of propagation that create narrative tension. Indrāṇī begins acting before receiving Burhbā's advice; her leadership is not merely an echo of his directions.

A Community Awakened from Sleep: Initial Disorder

The people awaken and begin trying to put out the flames with water, sand, and wet cloth. Strong wind defeats these first efforts. Thus the chapter does not present a village that initially does nothing: spontaneous action occurs but achieves only limited success as danger grows. The course of events moves from improvised attempts toward an organized human chain. The early helpers are not individually named or given distinct

speeches, but neither are they simply spectators. They act, although they cannot yet contain the disaster.

Ten Brahmin Houses and Five Kayastha Houses: The Limits of the Numbers

The narrator says that ten houses burn in the Brahmin quarter and five in the Kayastha quarter; part of the temple is damaged as well. Later, "one-quarter of the village's houses" are said to have burned. It would be unwarranted to calculate from these statements that the village contained exactly sixty houses. The initial narration describes the spread across several quarters, without providing a complete list of damage in all of them. The figures for two named quarters and the summary of overall losses cannot simply be equated. Their narrative function is to convey the scale of suffering, not to furnish a complete census.

Losses by Quarter and Unnamed Communities

Damage to Brahmin and Kayastha houses and to the temple is specified, whereas losses in the other quarters are not enumerated by name. Since the fire is said to spread between quarters, it cannot be inferred that all other residents escaped unharmed. The narratological question concerns which places become visible through numbers and which disappear into the collective expression "the entire village." This selective presentation of caste-associated damage is a matter for critical analysis; it is not an invitation to invent additional incidents in other communities.

The Burning of Part of the Temple: Damage to a Communal Symbol

"One part" of the village temple burns. Even this brief statement places a building of religious and communal significance within the danger. But it does not identify an affected image, pavilion, ritual vessel, manuscript, or person. Fire reaches a material embodiment of the village's culture, while the prose gives more detailed attention to its approach toward the Channā Grove. The temple's partial damage belongs alongside the loss of dwellings; representing it as total destruction would contradict the text.

The Channā Grove: The Body of Memory under Threat

As the fire moves toward the grove, the narrative rises from the threatened loss of individual houses to the possible destruction of a memorial landscape built up over generations. Chapter [–70] made the grove an extension of Burhbā's body and a living collection of memories. The possibility of its burning therefore threatens the entire site of the novel's remembrance practices, not simply its leaves and branches. The later outcome partly resolves this anxiety: some trees at the edge are burned or scorched, while the central peepal remains safe.

Indrāṇī and Burhbā's Unprecedented Tone of Voice

Indrāṇī hears in Burhbā's reply a mixture of fear and determination unlike anything she has heard from him before. The long-lived witness, who has calmly advised people in earlier episodes, now experiences the crisis as a direct danger to himself. The narrator conveys the difference in his voice through Indrāṇī's apprehension, a subtle movement of focalization. His uncertainty—whether he can stop the fire himself—gives his character both a limit to power and a recognizable experience of fear.

"My Power Is of Memory, Not of Fire": A Character's Limit

This declaration provides the central definition of Burhbā's powers in the chapter. He associates his ability with preserving memory, not with directly controlling flames. In "Waiting for Relief," he distinguished the preservation of names from the work people must undertake to survive. Here, too, extinguishing the fire is entrusted to human hands. Consequently, the strangely sudden slowing of the flames cannot be used as straightforward proof that Burhbā exercises direct control over fire. His own account of his powers must remain distinct from the narrator's similes.

Joṛī Pond: A Familiar Place Put to New Use

Burhbā suggests Joṛī Pond as the source of water. In earlier water-related episodes the pond was linked to memory, labour, crocodiles, and communal festivities; in this chapter it becomes a practical resource for stopping fire. This transformation recalls the Channā Grove's use as a common kitchen during the famine: the geography of remembrance becomes an instrument for preserving present life. The water level, distance from the grove, and actual volume of water are not specified. The relation between places is narratively clear, but no exact geographical map is furnished.

The Incomplete "Perhaps": The Meaning of an Unfinished Sentence

Burhbā says that if water can be directed toward the grove, "perhaps…" The unfinished sentence dramatizes the impossibility of an unequivocal guarantee in a terrifying moment. Indrāṇī grasps the proposed measure before hearing a full explanation, and the story turns immediately to action. The omission of a completed statement increases dramatic speed and allows the reader to supply an expectation. Here dialogue works through interruption, inference, and urgency rather than extended instruction.

From the Pond to the Grove: A New Route of Collective Action

Indrāṇī sends able villagers running toward the pond; buckets of water pass from hand to hand in the direction of the grove. Bodies bridge the distance between locations. "Running" establishes urgency, "bucket after bucket" establishes repetition, and "hand to hand" gives the action a rhythm of mutual dependence. The narrator does not name every person, but the physical sequence is concrete. Burhbā's tentative advice becomes an enacted communal effort.

The Women's Night Assembly Forms the Human Chain

The women of the night assembly use their organizational experience to establish the chain between pond and grove. After its involvement in the hearing of domestic violence in Chapter [–66] and famine distribution in [–62], the institution now takes on a third task: organizing protection against fire. Its domain changes with each return—justice, food, and fire-fighting. This is how the novel makes earlier episodes productive within later action. Still, it gives no independent scene of a particular member's leadership, logistical difficulties, or shortage of equipment.

Hundreds of Hands: The Visible Collective Hero

"Hundreds of hands" appear as one large movement. The expression conveys extensive participation without identifying everyone, giving a distribution by gender, or explaining different physical capacities. The narrative thus makes Indrāṇī a central organizer while presenting the villagers as a collective hero. These bodies are not simply an impressive number: each hand in the succession is needed to move the buckets onward. The logic of action makes cooperation, rather than individual prowess, the foundation of the rescue.

The Flames Suddenly Slow: What Is Seen and What Is Inferred

As the fire reaches the roots of the peepal, it slows "suddenly," "as though" the roots of the trees were resisting it. The phrase "as though" marks a comparison. The text does not separately establish that the roots become conscious soldiers and physically repel the flames. The moment places an almost magical image alongside practical attempts to bring water. The decisive mechanism by which the fire slows—water, terrain, roots, or changing wind—is not separately narrated. Realistic rescue and figurative participation by nature coexist without a definitive causal settlement.

Indrāṇī's Later Account: Did the Leaves Confuse the Flames?

The narrator reports that Indrāṇī later said it had seemed to her that the grove's leaves moved together and confused the flames, causing them to lose their way. The source of this description is her retrospective memory,

not an omniscient declaration about the material behaviour of fire at the time. “It seemed” and “as though” are significant qualifiers. The leaves’ movement is an image of perception; their intention to mislead flames is a personification. Distinguishing these levels is essential to the subtlety of the novel’s magical experience.

The Peepal Unharmed and Trees at the Edge Damaged

By dawn, several marginal trees in the Channā Grove are burned or scorched, the greater part of the grove survives, and the “peepal, the heart of the grove,” is “completely unharmed.” Chapter [–70] extended Burhbā’s being through many trees; the new episode tests that configuration with damage at the margins and survival at the centre. The intact peepal becomes an exceptionally strong source of relief, but it would contradict the text to claim that the entire grove escaped without damage. The success of the rescue includes an acknowledged degree of loss.

Dawn: A Night-Long Crisis in Compressed Form

The lamp falls and the fire spreads in an instant, but the flames are finally extinguished “by the time dawn came.” An extended night of danger is thus compressed into a few swift scenes and summaries of repeated action. The prose gives no hour-by-hour account of the fire line, fatigue, or water supply. The rhythm changes from explosive beginning to sustained struggle and then to a slower, steadier resolution. Dawn signifies not only the return of light but the narrative transition from emergency to consequence.

Houses Burned, Deaths Not Narrated: A Crucial Song–Prose Difference

The folk song “New Fire from Ashes” declares, “Those who survived rebuilt; those who died had their names preserved.” The prose records burned houses, partial damage to the temple, scorched trees, and rebuilding, but it does not explicitly depict anyone dying in this fire. Equally, it does not expressly certify that nobody died: the prose is silent about fire-related mortality. The lyric’s general principle of remembering the dead must therefore not be transformed into a fabricated list of deaths in this particular disaster. The distinction between the textual levels is decisive.

A New Hearth from Ashes: Where Is the Song’s Scene in the Prose?

The opening proverb and the song repeat the image of a new hearth being lit from ashes. The prose says that villagers rebuild burned houses and introduce safety measures, including a separate position for lamps, but does not depict the lighting of a new hearth in every dwelling. The song

presents domestic renewal through a compact image; the prose concludes with collective learning about protection against fire. Separating these functions allows the lyric's cultural metaphor of rebirth and the narrative's actual reconstruction to be understood together.

Names Were Not Burned: The Poetic Continuity of Memory

The opening assertion "Fire took houses, not names" expresses faith that remembrance survives physical devastation. Houses are lost, but the community's repeated naming and Burhbā's memory endure, in keeping with the novel's continuing theme. The prose, however, does not assert that every written document survived, every leaf remained intact, or the possibility of forgetting was eliminated. The cultural certainty of the proverb and the material vulnerability of the village remain simultaneous aspects of the composition.

"Did You Yourself Stop the Fire?": Indrāṇī's Final Question

Sitting amid the ashes, Indrāṇī asks Burhbā whether he had personally stopped the fire. The question reopens the mystery of its unexpected slowing at the level of character dialogue. Had the story wished to establish an unequivocal miracle, a positive answer would have been available. Instead Burhbā replies in the negative, acknowledging the villagers' hands and his own knowledge of the pond's location. Their exchange gives the reader a practical resolution to the expectation of magical intervention, while the unusual movement of leaves retains an element of mystery.

Burhbā's Modest Role: Guide, Not Firefighter

Burhbā explains, "I only knew where the water was." In this brief statement, his long memory of the village's places becomes a source of useful advice, while the actual work belongs to people. His supernatural intervention is not definitively established as the means by which the fire was stopped; it remains at the level of a fearful possibility and Indrāṇī's impression. The dialogue holds realistic collective action and a magical guardian of memory in deliberate balance.

Reconstruction: The Final Summary of Events

Once the fire is out, the villagers rebuild the burned houses more safely. They establish separate places for lamps, emergency stores of water, and new rules for preventing fires. The story explicitly presents this as an institutional adaptation born of danger. It does not show which house is rebuilt first, where supplies come from, whether cultivation stops, or where displaced families sleep in the meantime. Reconstruction is narrated as a summary of communal improvement rather than as a detailed account of the prolonged hardships of recovery.

The Disaster Remembered as Folklore: From Event to Lesson for Generations

"The Night of Fire" is said to become a tale passed on to each new generation of villagers. A single emergency becomes a repeated cultural lesson. The narrator does not stage individual scenes of its retelling to successive groups of listeners; the statement about future generations is a broad temporal summary. Chapter [−65] likewise converted the fake-ghost episode into a warning tale, but here the instruction is connected to material rules for fire safety. The passage from occurrence to practice and then to story belongs to the novel's larger structure.

The Moral Generalization about Nature: A Distance from the Original Cause

The conclusion suggests that nature's power is frightening, but human unity can be more effective. Yet the initial danger arose from the combined effects of a lamp's unsafe position, dry straw, and unusually strong wind. The human contribution to risk can become obscured beneath the final representation of overwhelming nature. In fact, the new safety rules respond precisely to the preventable elements of that initial chain. Reading the chapter's moral requires remembering its material beginning. The tension grants the conclusion breadth, while blurring the specificity of the cause.

The Limits of the Collective Hero: Whose Voices Are Heard?

Indrāṇī, Burhbā, and the women's night assembly are the main named or identifiable voices of organization. The hundreds of helpers, residents of burned houses, children, older people, and people of various quarters receive only compressed individual treatment. The story conveys the breadth of communal courage without giving much space to the unequal experiences of suffering. No independent speech is provided for a mother whose house burns, a worker handling fuel, or the keeper of the grain store. These absences do not deny that such people existed in the fictional world; they mark the literary limits of its concentration on collective leadership.

Overall Narrative Judgment: Flames, Water, and the Memorial Grove

The chapter's strength lies in its combination of the swift outbreak of fire, Indrāṇī's view from the window, flames spreading in the wind, a human chain between pond and grove, and Burhbā's recognition of his own limits. Institutions established in earlier chapters find new and consequential uses. Two significant differences remain: the seasonal interval between the autumn of Chapter [−61] and Jyeṣṭha of [−60] cannot

fit within the stated month; and the song refers to the remembrance of the dead even though the prose depicts no definite fire-related death. The slowing of the flames retains an unresolved combination of communal action and images of nature that appear magical; it is not an unambiguous assertion of a miracle.

Sources, Limits, and the Next Movement of the Trilogy

The primary source is Chapter [–60], "The Night of Fire," including "New Fire from Ashes," the exchanges between Indrāṇī and Burhbā, the description of damage at dawn, and the final rebuilding. The number of people who might have died in the fire, the distance covered by the bucket chain, the complete distribution of house losses by caste quarter, and individual families' experiences of recovery are not specified. In the next section, [–59], "The Second Flood," the narrative turns from drought and burning land toward the opposite environmental danger: an excess of water.

Critical Section 42 | Original Chapter −59 — The Second Flood

The Prehistory · The recurrence of flooding, the sound of early warning, the geography of the leatherworkers' quarter, and remembrance transformed into a means of saving lives

The original novel's chapter begins on page 280; the next chapter [−58] begins on page 284. The estimated page span, based on the contents, is therefore 280–283.

The Chapter's Centre: Returning Water and a Changed Village

The decisive creative question in "The Second Flood" is not simply the return of the water, but the village's changed conduct when confronted with a repeated catastrophe. The Kamalā-Balān again breaches its confines; as in the first flood, danger approaches the embankment near the southern leatherworkers' quarter. Yet the story does not reproduce the first flood's terrible outcome. A collective warning system, previously designated places of safety, and Indrāṇī's planning ensure that this time there is no loss of life. The narrator makes this difference the explicit outcome. "First" and "second" are not merely chronological labels: they designate two stages in the development of a village understood as a collective character. The change in the community's decisions matters more narratively than a comparison of the volume or force of the two floods.

The Opening Proverb: A Reading Prescribed in Advance

"The second flood knows the old way, yet inflicts fresh wounds; the village that endured a flood learned to read the water." This opening supplies an interpretive structure before the principal events are narrated. The flood's "knowing the way" personifies nature; the village's "reading the water" turns experience into decipherable signs. In this linguistic parallel, the river returns by its old course while human beings learn to understand its return before it is too late. Because the reader is alerted beforehand to the possibility of success, uncertainty diminishes, but the dramatic tension does not disappear: at what cost, at which point will the embankment break, and what are the limits of protection? The proverb is an orientation for reading the chapter, not a guarantee of invulnerable safety.

The Folk Song "Reading the Water": A Compressed Collective Narrative

The flood song "Reading the Water" brings a past event, present preparations, and an anticipated future into a single rhythm. The statement "The first flood brought fear; the second brought knowledge"

fashions complex communal experience into a two-stage lesson. The song's images of placing grain high up, securing livestock, and raising houses bear upon the particular evacuation plan described in the prose. But the prose does not say that every house was raised. The song expresses the voice of an idealized community; the prose relates the decisions of particular agents and the breach of an embankment. To merge the two levels would turn a song's instructive possibilities into fabricated details of events actually depicted.

Three Months after the Fire: Environmental Time Enters the Narrative

The main narrative begins "three months after the fire." Its movement from the preceding chapter's sudden nocturnal blaze to a prolonged rainy season is clear. The formulation "day and night, without stopping" compresses many hours or days of rain into a short paragraph; no exact count of days is given. The anticipation that the river will cross its boundaries foreshadows the outcome but is not a separate foreknowledge possessed by every family in the village. Narrative time is brief, the environmental duration of the disaster comparatively long, and the decisive night once more receives scenic emphasis. Rain is not a decorative background but a material force that drives the plot.

The Limits of the Kamalā-Balān: Riverine Action and Metaphor

The prose says that the Kamalā-Balān and the surrounding streams "forgot their limits." "Forgot" is a humanized description of rising floodwater, not evidence of a river's conscious guilt or intention. Within the narrated action the river increases the pressure of the water, weakens the embankment, and transforms the terrain. Burhbā's perception of the water's "anger" belongs to his language of experience, not to a separately established natural cause. The distinction matters: the agency of water in the narrative arises from its destructive effects, not from declaring the river a moral person in human form. The coexistence of material hydrology and popular feeling constitutes the chapter's environmental technique.

The Masonry Embankment: Testing a Structure Built after the First Flood

After the first flood [–89], a barrier of fired bricks and stone was built to protect the leatherworkers' quarter; the village's name "Garh" is also said to be connected with its memory. This chapter tests that long-standing defensive arrangement against a fresh disaster. The embankment, "considered strong since Sukhdev Mahto's time," carries a reference to the past, not a record of maintenance in each intervening year. The

embankment trembles; a plan is devised to reinforce it with sandbags and timber; eventually one section gives way. These are three different stages. The failed portion does not make the community's entire accumulated learning futile. That learning is visible in the multiple measures taken beyond the wall itself: evacuation and warning.

The Southern Leatherworkers' Quarter: Social Memory in a Revisited Place

A section of the embankment on the southern side of the leatherworkers' quarter—the place first reached by the waters in the earlier flood—breaks again. The return of this location is not neutral geography; it awakens the memory of inequalities represented in the earlier chapter. In [–89], poor maintenance and the neglect of names in relief records were explicit. Here, at the least, a common system of warning reaches across the village. The present chapter does not, however, establish that every family in the leatherworkers' quarter received equal protection for its home, goods, and livelihood compared with families elsewhere. The absence of deaths is an important achievement; an equal distribution of social losses cannot be inferred from it.

Indrāṇī's First Scene: Running, a Rain-Soaked Body, and an Appeal

Indrāṇī, drenched in the heavy rain, runs to the peepal tree. This is the chapter's first sharply focused human scene. The preceding paragraphs survey an extensive river landscape; now the point of attention contracts to one woman's body, fear, and urgent speech. Her question, "Flood after fire?" arranges events into an accumulating sequence of crises. She is not merely a carrier of information; she brings to Burhbā the fear of an impending destruction of the community. The prose registers her soaked body but gives no itinerary, companions, or account of the condition of her own home. The scene centres the emotional turning point of communal leadership rather than an extended private biography.

Burhbā's Sensation in the Roots: An Unusual Expansion of Focalization

From the roots of the peepal, Burhbā senses "every pulse" of the rising water. This capacity, unlike that of an ordinary human character, creates a partly supernatural focalization joining tree, earth, and water. Yet the chapter does not say that he redirects the water, prevents the embankment from breaking, or performs a miraculous rescue. His awareness conveys the intensity of the crisis; Indrāṇī's plan supplies its practical answer. In [–89], Burhbā felt terror and powerlessness when he wished to save the villagers. This time he passes his accumulated recollections to Indrāṇī. Through the

recurrence, the role of the long-lived witness shifts from miraculous action toward the transmission of memory.

The First Seven Lives: An Earlier Tragedy Retold Within the Story

Burhbā tells Indrāṇī directly of the seven people who died in the first flood. In [–89], the account names Subhāgī and six others; the pain of the failure to record those six properly was also described. A whole previous episode is condensed here into one formula of remembrance. It recalls "what happened before" for the reader and provides the comparative standard against which the later outcome, "not a single life lost," is judged. Yet the mention of seven deaths does not restage the complete social history of the first flood. A reader who has not read [–89] receives a number without the distinct lives of the dead.

"Angrier" Water: A Comparison of Feeling, Not a Measurement

Burhbā says the present waters "seem angrier" than the earlier flood. The qualification "seem" marks the limit of the perception. It does not prove that the current flood has objectively higher levels, greater velocity, a larger area of spread, or greater scientific intensity. The narrative gives no measurements of that kind. The speech nevertheless serves a dramatic function: past experience cannot become a warrant for inactivity, since the new crisis may be more severe. The conjunction of an apparently more dangerous present and improved preparation defeats the simplistic assurance that learning from one disaster makes the next one harmless.

From Panic to Planning: Indrāṇī's Change of State

After speaking with Burhbā, Indrāṇī summons "every quarter" of the village and devises an immediate plan. The principal narrative action is not merely hearing advice, but converting a decision into the organization of collective work. The plan follows three directions: reinforcing the weak portions of the embankment with sandbags and timber; sending older people and children in advance to higher ground; and arranging boats and ropes for possible use. This is not a magical leap from a frightened woman to an unshakable heroine. It is the further application of abilities already developed during the night of fire. The prose does not establish how many bags were used or boats launched, or how far each measure succeeded. Plans and completed actions must remain distinct.

Three Preparations, Three Different Temporal Functions

Sandbags and timber are intended for immediate resistance at the embankment; the early removal of older people and children reduces their exposure before the danger arrives; boats and ropes are contemplated for a possible emergency. The narrative does not present all three as equally

implemented or equally successful interventions. One section of the embankment breaks, the evacuation has already begun, but there is no specific scene counting people rescued by boat. It would obliterate a crucial narrative distinction to claim that every planned measure was successfully performed. Indrāṇī's practical intelligence consists in providing several alternatives; the decisive observable signs of success are the functioning warning and the arrival of people at places of safety.

The Embankment Breaks at Night: Expectation and Outcome Diverge

Night deepens and, finally, one section on the south side of the leatherworkers' quarter gives way. "Finally" signals the outcome of prolonged pressure. Since the reader knows that the embankment has been trembling, the breach is not an entirely unforeseen surprise. The true dramatic reversal lies in the next information: by then, bells, drums, and agreed warning signals are already operating. The failure of physical defence is counterbalanced by the success of social warning. Rather than fashioning a miracle in which the embankment remains intact, the narrative presents a limited victory: although the embankment breaks, people live.

The Warning System: Distributing Time Across the Community

Bells, drum rhythms, and predetermined signals are the chapter's auditory media. In the first flood, Gaurī's dream and her grandmother's cry carried warning; now the community does not depend on the extraordinary hearing of a single person. A shared code transmits the same moment of danger to different parts of the village. The incoming water is physically at unequal distances from particular houses, but the time of warning becomes collective. The distinction among song as sign, disaster warning as sign, and the narrative's anticipatory sign gives the chapter its sound-based structure.

The Drum Played by Mohan's Descendants: A Function Passed Down Through a Name

Mohan's descendants maintain the tradition of drumming and now play the "danger rhythm." The individual drummer's name is not supplied; identity is determined through lineage and artistic labour. The device connects the long novel's gaps between generations to the functional continuity of an inherited practice. An instrument of cultural performance becomes an instrument of public survival. "Mohan's descendants," however, is a collective designation. The narrator specifies neither how many played nor which rhythm was heard in each quarter. With that limitation, the drum's sound remains one of the chapter's most consequential nonhuman vehicles of narration.

A Rhythm Learned in Childhood: The Narrative Reward of Repetition

The narrator says that every inhabitant knew the "danger rhythm" from childhood. The effective common response at the moment of crisis is therefore attributed to prior learning. The novel does not dramatize the training sessions, but it gives present consequences to a rhythm understood as regularly taught. "Repeated again and again" denotes the recurrence of sound during this night, while "from childhood" evokes repetition across generations. The drumming of one moment carries the accumulated practice of many years. Such temporal density is a success of the narrative of communal memory, although the diversity of actual training remains outside its scenic scope.

Echoes Through Dark Lanes: Effects Across Unseen Space

The principal prose describes how the rhythm acts upon dark lanes, closed houses, and families running from their homes. Sound, rather than illumination, constructs the village's geography. People whose houses lie far apart are joined by a common auditory relation. The narrator does not name each household, but a collective scene emerges from the changes in action prompted by the same rhythm. Sound is not simply an ornament of collective heroism: when the warning arrives before the floodwater, the sequence of events changes. The system of signals is thus a practical instrument for controlling narrative time.

Gaurī's Dream and the Public Drum: Rewriting an Earlier Event Across Generations

In [−89], Gaurī heard Burhbā's "Get up!" in a dream; her grandmother recognized her voice and warned the houses. In the present chapter that individual imperative has become the public grammar of an agreed rhythm. The means in the two chapters differ, but their narrative function develops in the same direction: warning others of a crisis. The historical change does not consist in eliminating ghostly memory; it lies in turning an exceptional experience into communal conduct. The novel does not supply every intermediate moment of instruction. The reader must join two widely separated scenes to grasp the transformation.

High Ground and the Old Cremation Site: The Transformation of Place

Indrāṇī proposes sending the elderly and children toward the "old cremation ground," explicitly recalling "the time of Gaurī." In [−89], the ground, ordinarily considered inauspicious, served as refuge for Gaurī's family. It is now remembered beforehand as an approved place of safety. Its actual elevation and its changed cultural significance work together: a

place for the rites of death enters the map of survival. The narrative does not establish its capacity, the actual size of the crowd, or its facilities. The return of the site demonstrates the usefulness of memory, not the existence of a fully described resettlement arrangement.

Priority for the Elderly and Children: An Ethic of Protection and Its Limits

Older people and children constitute the first priority of Indrāṇī's evacuation plan. This choice links critically to the recollection of the aged Subhāgī's helplessness in [–89]. In that earlier tragedy, delayed evacuation and bodily incapacity contributed to the loss of life; here a safe place is identified in advance. The prose does not separately describe who assisted each elderly person, the actual transport of people with disabilities, the condition of pregnant women, or how boats were used. A literary indication of protective priorities is not a complete report of universally accessible evacuation. Even within this limitation, the identification of particular vulnerable groups makes the narrative's ethics concrete.

Constructing a Collective Character: "Every Quarter" and "Every Family"

The expansive formulas "summoning every quarter" and warning "every family" make the village a collective character. Individual differences recede and common purpose comes forward. Indrāṇī is the named face of leadership, Mohan's descendants carry the message through sound, and Burhbā speaks for long memory. Most other participants appear in summaries of action. The collective image does not necessarily contain each household's complex private story. The zero-death result means that people did survive, but not that their experiences of the crisis were uniform.

Women's Leadership and the Right to Be Seen: Indrāṇī, Gaurī, and Missing Voices

Gaurī was the central child's voice in the first flood; Indrāṇī leads in the present crisis. The mode of women's participation changes, from a girl's exceptional capacity to receive a warning to an adult woman's public planning and decisions. Indrāṇī is allowed both to acknowledge fear and to apportion the work of prevention. Yet other women's deliberations, the particular risks faced by women in the leatherworkers' quarter, and the voices of rescued children receive no separate scenes. The visibility of a woman leader and the full plurality of women's experience are not identical achievements.

From a Soaked Body to Dawn Fatigue: Indrāṇī's Emotional Arc

The chapter first shows Indrāṇī drenched, frightened, and running through rain; at its close she sits near the peepal in the light of dawn, exhausted but relieved. Between these bodily markers the account places several decisions and the results of collective protection. "Exhausted" ensures that the success is not an effortless miracle; it is a minimal memorial of the cost of labour. Yet her physical effort, the sleepless hours, and the inward memory of individual losses are mostly indications, not developed scenes. Emotional experience is placed at two milestones, intensifying the action rather than producing an extended interior monologue.

The Water Recedes at Dawn: Compression After the Climax

The rising water at night, the broken embankment, and the repeated drumbeats form a rapid sequence. Then, "by dawn," the narrative reports the recession of the water and contracts time abruptly. There is no hour-by-hour account of the receding flood, nor a detailed search after the disaster. The narrator moves directly from the night's struggle to the social meaning of its outcome. This pacing produces a distinct dramatic curve: apprehension, preparation, breach, warning, and preservation of life. Its limitation is that the bodily duration of the extreme crisis receives comparatively little depiction.

"Not a Single Life Was Lost": The Precise Limits of an Outcome

The narrator states unequivocally that several houses were swept away and fields ruined, but this time "not a single life" in the village was lost. Against the seven deaths of the first flood, zero is the chapter's decisive difference. It is an assertive fact inside the story; a critic must not manufacture deaths to contradict it. Yet "not a single life was lost" does not entail that nobody was injured, that every animal survived, that no family was displaced, or that economic damage was slight. The narrative intensifies the achievement of preserving human life while leaving the character and scale of other losses substantially undescribed.

Damage to Houses and Fields: Evidence Against an Untroubled Victory

The absence of deaths is cause for joy. At the same time, the narrator records that "several houses in the village were swept away and fields were ruined." Material failure and human survival belong to the same result. The account does not turn their coexistence into a miracle in which everything is safe. The village's subsequent economy, the temporary shelter of displaced households, crop losses, debt, and the return to work are left

unexamined. The distinction matters: the chapter succeeds as a drama of evacuation, not as a complete narrative of rehabilitation. The following disease chapter [–58] reopens the crisis after the waters recede, so the victory at dawn is not the final resolution of the cycle.

Counting the Dead: The Six Unnamed Victims of the First Flood

Of the seven who died in [–89], Subhāgī is named, while the names of the other six were not properly entered in administrative records. In this context the phrase "record of zero deaths" carries particular weight. The earlier archive failed, while a positive result is now asserted through a figure. But the novel does not specify which body created the new record, which lists of names it holds, or who compiled the distribution of losses by caste or locality. "Record" remains a narratorial formula of outcome, not a reproduced document. The old tension among memory, counting, and writing remains unresolved.

Repaying the Debt to Gaurī: The Emotion of Inherited Memory

After the flood, Indrāṇī tells Burhbā, "Today I have repaid Gaurī's debt." The gap of many generations is compressed into one utterance. She does not treat success as a private reward for individual heroism, but as an answer to an obligation arising from earlier suffering. Gaurī's name becomes an active motive in public history. This "debt," however, is not an actual instruction Gaurī gave to Indrāṇī; it is a descendant's moral rereading of a previous life-threatening event. The declaration does not change the past—Subhāgī cannot be brought back—but it alters the meaning of a present decision.

Subhāgī's Name: Grief Preserved Within Success

Indrāṇī explicitly remembers that "on that day Grandmother Subhāgī could not be saved." One name emerges from the figure of seven deaths, preserving grief in an identifiable life. Subhāgī's death enters the scene of relief at dawn and forms a critical backdrop to the present celebration. The remembrance prevents victory from becoming an innocent festival. The other six names do not return, however, and readers can recall the problem of the earlier archive. The recurrence of one name sharpens feeling while exposing the narrative anonymity of the other lives.

Burhbā's Final Answer: Memory as Knowledge That Preserves Life

Burhbā's concluding words describe his memory becoming, "in your hands, knowledge that saves lives, and not merely names." This is the chapter's most consequential moment of narrative self-interpretation. After [–89], his promise had centred on preventing the names of the dead from being forgotten. Now remembrance becomes an instrument of

collective decision-making. The sentence does not simply oppose two roles —remembering the dead and preserving the living. Experience from the first inspires the action required for the second. Nor does it suggest that Burhbā personally saved everyone through supernatural power: planning, signals, and evacuation are collective human tasks.

The Changing Form of the "Witness": From Presence to an Acting Society

The chapter rewrites Burhbā's position as a witness. During the first flood, he suffered because his solitary voice could not reach those at risk. Here knowledge accumulated through long memory is translated into action by organized social means. Indrāṇī decides, Mohan's descendants sound the warning, and families move toward agreed safe places. Memory is indispensable but insufficient without a common language and practice. Burhbā's description of the result as a "gift" is his emotional response to a social transformation, not the reward of a demonstrated miracle. The extraordinary witness does not displace the work of human beings.

Redoubled Recurrence: The Further Sequence of Fire, Water, and Disease

Chapters [−60] and [−59] present fire and flood as different natural events, linked by Indrāṇī's leadership and the use of previous experience. Water from the pond saved the grove during the fire; the same general element returns in a vast destructive form during the flood. Its function reverses: a life-saving resource becomes a source of danger. The original story then opens [−58] with a new illness associated with dirty water left standing after the flood. The present chapter's safe dawn is thus an intermediate achievement, not the end of the wider crisis. The impending development compels the reader to question the finality of celebration.

The Social System of Protection and the Limits of Representation

The story says that "every quarter" was included, but gives no distinct dialogue to inhabitants of the leatherworkers' quarter in the specific decisions. The embankment breaks in their direction; whether they suffered a disproportionate number of lost houses is not established. The contemporary roles of the women's assembly and state employees are also briefly treated. Against the background of discriminatory record-keeping in the first flood, these silences matter. The critic should not invent another episode of discrimination. Rather, the question is narratological: whose voice becomes visible, and whose is absorbed into the narrative summary of a collective?

The Folk Song's Promised Future and the Actual Damage in Prose

The song declares, "Those who learned from disaster did not drown in the next," and, more expansively, were "not troubled by the flood." The prose does demonstrate the preservation of lives, but also records a broken embankment, houses swept away, and devastated fields. Consequently, "did not drown" is consistent with the symbolism of survival; an unqualified assertion of freedom from trouble exceeds the evidence of the story. The song's consolatory collective voice and the prose's mixed outcome have different functions. Their divergence is part of the novel's layered narration; it should not be silently flattened into a simple success story.

Remaining Uncertainties of Chronology, Geography, and Causation

The prose dates the flood "three months after the fire," but supplies no precise calendar year, measurement of water, date of embankment repair, number of boats, or total damage to homes and fields. The first flood [–89] belongs to a much earlier generation; the lineage sequence offers a long background of memory, not a complete historical calendar. That the embankment broke and that nobody died are both source-established; the elimination of all risks is not. The creative causal sequence is primarily "accumulated learning → early warning → evacuation → preservation of life," although its practical intermediate stages are not all described with material precision.

Narrative Technique: Summary, Dialogue, Warning Scene, and Emotional Epilogue

The chapter's pace can be divided into four broad movements: a summary of extraordinary rainfall; the exchange between Indrāṇī and Burhbā; collective evacuation signalled by sound while the embankment breaks; and the dawn outcome followed by an exchange about remembrance. Dialogue is central twice: at the beginning it establishes why warning is needed, and at the end it interprets the achievement. Much of the intervening work is compressed into accounts of communal action. The economical design gives the result force, but leaves private physical struggles, social losses, and difficult choices in the rescue less developed. The success and the limitation arise from the same compression.

A Balanced Reckoning of Achievements and Discrepancies

The distinctive achievement of "The Second Flood" is to reactivate the place of the first flood, its number of dead, the memory of Gaurī and Subhāgī, and a new system of rescue within a single narrative structure. Indrāṇī is the practical answer to this accumulated history; the drums of

Mohan's descendants form its common language. Zero deaths is the chapter's centre, but losses of homes and fields preserve its complexity. The limitations remain: the material failure of the embankment is briefly treated; voices from the leatherworkers' quarter are limited; the outcomes of every component of the evacuation plan are not specified; and the song's assurance that no one was "troubled" conflicts with the suffering described in prose. This is an effective exemplum of long memory made life-saving, not a complete social history of relief.

Source Limits and the Door to the Next Chapter

The primary textual basis of this review is original Chapter [−59], "The Second Flood"; the folk song "Reading the Water"; the two dialogues between Indrāṇī and Burhbā; the breach on the southern side of the leatherworkers' quarter; and the result at dawn. The comparative basis is Chapter [−89], "The First Night, the First Flood," with its seven dead, Gaurī's warning, Subhāgī's death, and the masonry embankment; the immediately preceding fire in [−60]; and the water-related illness in [−58], "The Third Calamity." The following chapter destabilizes the apparent happy ending of the flood by revealing another kind of danger in its aftermath.

Critical Section 43 | Original Chapter −58 — The Third Calamity

The Prehistory · The triad of fire, flood, and disease; accumulated memory in communal practice; the names of the dead; and collective continuity

According to the original contents, this chapter begins on page 284, and Chapter [−57] begins on page 288. The estimated span is 284–287; this is not independent pagination for each quotation.

The Third Form of Disaster: The Final Turn in a Narrative Sequence

Although "The Third Calamity" is a distinct narrative of crisis, it cannot be read apart from the two preceding chapters. Fire in [−60] and the flood in [−59] had come to an end, but [−58] opens by showing that the recession of floodwater does not mean that danger has passed. Water left standing and decaying in the village becomes the environment in which another disease begins. The novel thereby shifts its account of disaster away from a sudden external blow toward the consequences remaining after it. Its underlying narrative question becomes: "What remains after the event?" During the first two calamities Indrāṇī and the village confronted visibly immediate threats. Here the spread of a less visible illness once more tests their accumulated exhaustion, social organization, and capacity to put knowledge to use.

The Ordinal Title: The Structural Meaning of "Third"

"The Third Calamity" does not name the disease; it names a position in a sequence. To understand the chapter, readers must retain the earlier history of fire, flood, and illness. The advantage of such numbering is that the disastrous year becomes a single narrative unit. Its limitation is that the distinct experience of particular victims can become absorbed in the aggregate pattern of numbered calamities. The title foregrounds "three" before the experience of illness, mortality, or medical practice. Structural recurrence in this way governs the presentation of personal stories. "Third" here is a chronological designation, not a classification of diseases in scientific terms.

The Opening Proverb: Falling and Standing Again

"One calamity teaches, the third puts one to the test; whoever falls three times stands firm the fourth." The proverb connects repeated injury with a sequence of learning. Three falls and a fourth rising produce a folk-tale expectation of resilience. Yet "standing" does not mean that every body, home, field, and member of the village remains intact. Some people die later in this chapter. The saying must therefore be read as a folk expression

of collective continuity, not as evidence that every individual survived unharmed. It directs the reader's emotional anticipation in advance, while the prose reveals both the price and the limits of that optimism.

"Three Calamities, Standing at the Fourth": The Song's Future Memory

The opening "song of courage" sings of fire, flood, and the third ordeal as if they already formed a closed narrative. The prose only subsequently explains the symptoms, treatment, and deaths. The song grasps those events beforehand in the language of having "endured" and having "recovered." Through this reversed arrangement, the reader encounters a possible ending of collective memory before reading the illness's actual struggle. A future act of retelling is brought into the present of the narrative. Suspense about the survival of the community diminishes, yet an emotional tension intensifies: if the community remains standing, which individual lives will not? The song's collective assurance and the prose's incomplete account of losses are not duplicates of the same meaning.

Repetition in the Song: A Collective Grammar of Courage

Formulas such as "Fire came, flood came," "We fell three times," and "the village did not break" recur in the song. Their repetition places different crises within the same rhythm of remembrance. This makes the collective experience readily memorable, but risks flattening the distinctive nature of different diseases, injuries, and persons. The song speaks of those who faced calamity "with a smile"; Indrāṇī in the prose expresses fear in an exhausted voice. Endurance and exhaustion coexist in the narrated experience. The confident diction of the folk melody cannot wholly replace personal experience. The two narrative registers both enrich and qualify one another.

The After-Story of Receding Water: An Incomplete Dawn of Relief

At the end of [−59], the floodwater receded at dawn and the narrator declared that not a single person had died. The first sentence of [−58] turns to the residue of that apparently finished disaster. The words "after the water had receded" make the chapters continuous. Despite their separate titles, they are succeeding layers of a larger environmental event. Successful evacuation during the flood does not automatically produce long-term protection of health. The narrator withdraws some of the emotional simplicity of the previous victory. Preserving lives, losing livelihoods, and facing illness emerge as different timescales of disaster.

Decaying Water and Pits: An Unregarded Location Becomes the Source of Events

The chapter refers to pits of stagnant, foul water at several places. The pits are not assigned to a particular named pond or household, yet they become material conditions for the next event. In [−60], the Jorī pond helped extinguish a fire; in [−59], the Kamalā-Balān was the source of flood devastation; here stagnant, polluted water is represented as a source of danger. These successive states of water prevent a fixed classification of water as a consistently auspicious or inauspicious symbol. The narrative does not furnish a separate scientific account of transmission for each pit. It proposes a broad causal relation, not a detailed clinical or epidemiological report.

A Fortnight's Interval: The Delayed Arrival of Illness

Within "two weeks" of the floodwaters receding, symptoms begin to spread. This delay produces a different narrative temporality from the immediate crises of fire and flooding. The threat of a breaking embankment could be signalled by drums at once; the illness begins without a named first patient, a separately narrated first household, or a scene of the first transmission of information. The narrator condenses a span of time into the formula "within two weeks." The compression conveys the spread of a communal illness but leaves its earliest sufferers, their carers, and the path of the first warnings beyond the reader's view.

A Triad of Symptoms: The Body in a Compressed List

Abdominal pain, severe diarrhoea, and rapid dehydration provide the illness's narrative identity. The prose does not assign it a specific medical name; the critic should not make a definite diagnosis from these symptoms alone. The human body becomes the principal site of danger, but no single patient's intimate bodily experience, a night of suffering, or scene of recovery receives an independent development. This is more a narrative of communal control than a series of individual medical stories. The symptoms are concrete; their private histories remain outside the narrative frame.

Infants and Older People: Unnamed Groups of Vulnerable Bodies

The narrator says that the disease initially spread among children and older people and subsequently indicates that the very old and very young were especially represented among the dead. Such age-based exposure could become a central social question. Yet there is no name of a dead child, no household scene, no mother's individual testimony, and no account of an elder's earlier life. These general categories inform the reader of the kinds

of loss but do not bring individual grief close. Criticism must register the absence of a distinct linguistic place for these people without making up scenes for them or dismissing death as nothing more than an abstract count.

Indrāṇī Returns: The Exhausted Condition of Continuous Leadership

Indrāṇī, who has "already struggled through both fire and flood," again becomes the leading character. The narrator now represents her not solely as the energetic organizer of the earlier scenes, but as a person with an exhausted body and troubled mind. "Facing a third test" compresses the duration of her individual effort into a short phrase. The dawn after the flood offered relief but not a long rest; illness overtakes the accumulated fatigue. Thus the calamities do not form separate festivals of triumph in her life, but a nearly continuous sequence of repeated labour. Her exhaustion is important, although its specific personal consequences receive relatively little development.

"The Comet Was Right": A Character's Interpretation, Not a Narrative Fact

Indrāṇī tells Burhbā, "The comet was right," referring to the three calamities of fire, flood, and sickness. In [−61], however, Burhbā clearly stated that the comet itself brought no disaster and that causes lay on the earth. Indrāṇī's words must not therefore be promoted into the author's objective assertion of an astronomical cause. They represent a frightened character's effort to interpret an apparent coincidence and a sequence of events. The novel retains both a reasoned rejection of celestial causation and a manner of meaning-making resembling a folk prophecy. The tension can serve poetic foreshadowing, although it also leaves the possibility of ambiguity about the story-world's rules.

The Comet's Sequence: Foreshadowing and Retrospective Confirmation

The threatened crises in [−61], the fire in [−60], the flood in [−59], and the illness in [−58] create a successive pattern of anticipation. The initial signs do not give the exact disease, location, or number of future deaths. The introductory assertion that the comet's "third prediction" has come true should consequently be understood as a literary reclassification of events. By tying later events to an earlier fear, the writer creates an impression of fate. Descriptions of dirty water and the physician's work draw that impression back toward material causation. A premonition thus controls narrative expectation without becoming the physical cause of events.

Burhbā's Reply: Centuries of Memory and the Work of the Present

Burhbā directs Indrāṇī's attention to the experience of the ancestors. His words promise no miraculous future without destruction; they demand the application of accumulated learning in the present. He recalls the "collective remembrance" established during the epidemic in Vimalā's day, while also insisting on the need for "new, scientific knowledge." In this exchange, enduring memory is not the rival of new learning but a resource that can act alongside it. Burhbā himself does not provide a disease name, a medicine of established efficacy, or detailed instructions for every household. His role is to supply a historical connection; medical and practical work remains with other characters.

Burhbā Is Tired Too: The Humanly Legible Limit of an Extraordinary Being

The prose calls Burhbā himself "tired, but resolute." In a character attached to centuries of memory, exhaustion is not simply a description of an ordinary biological body; it registers the emotional burden of repeatedly witnessing social devastation. During the fire, questions arose about the limits of his power; in the flood, he recalled earlier methods of protection; facing illness, he joins memory with scientific measures. The narrator attributes tiredness to him but does not open its full interior development. That brief affective attribution narrows the distance between the extraordinary witness and the practical community.

Remembering Vimalā: A History Within the History

The recollection of Vimalā's "collective remembrance" during an earlier epidemic is an intertextual return within the novel's own narrative history. That event does not literally happen again before the present characters; it appears in Burhbā's compact retelling. Remembering Vimalā connects the moral courage of the living during a plague with the current need for practical measures against contaminated water. The story does not merely repeat the past; it shows the possibility of using a former practice of remembrance under new conditions. Exactly where Indrāṇī or the physician enacts Vimalā's particular ritual, however, is not independently dramatized.

The Physician Educated in Town: Knowledge Transferred Socially

The village physician is described as having studied in a new medical school in town. A single sentence brings together an urban educational institution and a rural emergency. His personal name, age, caste, journey, and curriculum are not given. He functions chiefly through what he does in the narrative. The assertion that he "recognized it immediately"

abbreviates the diagnostic process and moves the scene toward public instructions. This gives pace to the subsequent cooperative action, while reducing the complexity of individual professional judgement. The physician's function is decisive; his character is not fully developed.

Boiling Water and Preparing a Solution: Information Turned into Practice

The physician instructs every family to boil drinking water and teaches people to prepare a solution of salt and sugar. Within the original story, these are acts of communal health education. The literary analysis does not turn the narrative into a medical advisory document or an independently validated handbook of treatment. The cause of illness and the value of the measures appear as part of the speech of the characters and the narrator's organization of events. What matters narratively is that the physician does more than claim the authority to identify an illness: he works to extend knowledge into the ordinary actions of households. The distance between instruction and individually observed compliance remains compressed in the prose.

Sonmā Mājin's Descendants: A Tradition of Knowledge of Water

Sonmā Mājin's descendants assist in identifying safer sources of water and traditional forms of treatment. Sonmā's earlier narrative presence, especially in [–83], returns as a competence exercised by another generation. The present chapter gives no individual names, gender identifications, or conversations to these descendants. The collective term "descendants" makes them representatives of an inherited body of knowledge. This is a mark of respect but also a limit on independent characterization. The experience of a community that has worked with rivers becomes useful in the emergency, although the specific households and named sources of water involved remain unshown.

Ratnā's Descendants: The Narrative Force and Limits of Local Knowledge

Ratnā's descendants are also associated with traditional knowledge of medicinal plants. The original prose reports the identification of a plant said to arrest diarrhoea, but supplies neither its name nor its preparation, dosage, or separately measured results. Literary analysis must therefore restrict itself to the position attributed to local knowledge within the story; it cannot assert independently verified medical effectiveness. The continuity of Ratnā's family memory gives the episode coherence within the novel. Yet "descendants" again makes individuals into unnamed collective signs of a function. This combines continuity across epic time with a lack of particularized characters.

Three Sources of Knowledge: A Structure of Cooperation, Not Proof of Equality

The prose attributes the response to a conjunction of modern medicine, traditional herbal knowledge, and social organization. This triad runs parallel to the three calamities. A triad of dangers is met by a triad of responses, producing a deliberate structural symmetry. Yet this does not mean that the three means are described, tested, or demonstrated to have equal effects. The physician's instructions are relatively specific; the account of herbs is general; the women's house-to-house activity is organizational. The ethical harmony of the three is the narrative's chosen value. It does not establish equal empirical outcomes or scientific equivalence among the remedies.

The Women's Night Assembly: Another Use for an Existing Institution

The Women's Night Assembly goes from house to house to secure observance of rules concerning handwashing, boiled drinking water, and avoidance of dirty water. Following its earlier work distributing food during famine and forming the human chain in the fire of [−60], this institution functions as a recurring character of the story. It is not literally an individual, but it displays a learned capacity adapted to different emergencies. Labour usually relegated to the domestic sphere becomes public work to preserve life. The individual members, their disagreements, opposition encountered, and scarcity of resources are not separately presented. The institution is visible; internal conflicts within it are abbreviated.

The Reach of "Every House": Inclusive Language and Incomplete Scenes

The phrase "going to every house in the village" represents an ideal of collective reach. Yet no list of houses, distances, division of labour, resistant families, affected patients' homes, or service received by particular quarters is supplied. Remembering the unequal protection of the leatherworkers' quarter in [−89], such universal statements deserve special scrutiny. No specific act of discrimination in treatment is described in the present chapter, so the critic must not fabricate one. The literary question is how strongly the collective claim is supported by scenes involving particular people and locations. The answer is that the general declaration is extensive, but the local detail is limited.

The Gendering of Labour During Disaster: From Leadership to Routine Care

Indrāṇī speaks with Burhbā about the danger, while the women's assembly sustains daily arrangements for hygiene. These two scenes present women not merely as mourners or people waiting for news, but as leaders in crisis management. The physician is described in masculine terms, while the women's labour extends into households: the announcement of knowledge and the work required to implement it fall upon differently represented groups. The text does not open the members' particular decisions, resources, or personal exposure to illness. Thus the chapter establishes women's actual work, not the complete social outcome of empowerment. Visible action and unspoken conditions of labour require separate analysis.

A Map of What Happens: From Signs to Practical Effects

The sequence of changes is clear: foul stagnant water after the flood; symptoms spreading within two weeks; Indrāṇī's fearful conversation; Burhbā's recollection of the former epidemic; the trained physician's instructions; contributions of inherited knowledge of water and plants; the women's house-to-house campaign; control of the outbreak within three weeks; several deaths; and final collective remembrance. It would be mistaken to count every phrase as a wholly new dramatized event. Some are immediate dialogue, others report-like summaries, and still others subsequent institutional remembrance. There are two decisive turns: fear becomes a cooperative response, and the community decides upon continuity and remembrance despite the deaths that remain.

Narrating an Invisible Adversary: The Absence of Disease as a Visible Scene

The flames of the fire and the broken flood embankment appeared in vivid scenes. The hostile force of disease does not become equally visible here; it is presented through symptoms and communal results. The physician's "immediate recognition," the women's visits to "every house," and the eventual "control" of illness are compressed accounts of more extended happenings. This gives the chapter something like an administrative rhythm: the problem is identified, measures distributed, and results reported. The narrative moves efficiently, but personal fear of infection, the failure of particular treatments, and the last moments of the dead are seldom developed. This is an important limitation of the chosen mode of telling.

The Three-Week Conclusion: Temporal Compression and the Meaning of Control

"The disease was brought under control in three weeks" compresses the struggle and its outcome into a single sentence. The initial fortnight and the three weeks of control should not be treated as the same interval. The first refers to symptoms appearing after the floodwater recedes; the second marks the duration of the attempt to curb the illness. The narrator offers no daily patient figures, hospital scenes, or accounts of medicine distribution. The compression turns the disease into a third but time-limited chapter of crisis. It also leaves an important question: what became of the extended work of caring for survivors after the illness was controlled?

"Some Lives Were Lost": A Return to Death after the Flood's Zero

The narrator ended [–59] by saying that "not a single life" was lost in the flood. Here the account explicitly concedes that "some lives" were lost to illness. The statements are not contradictory: the first addresses direct flood losses, the second deaths from subsequent disease. In the reader's emotional sequence, however, the change is decisive. Death prevented through early evacuation returns through the polluted environment left behind. The prose gives no exact number, personal names, household lists, funeral scenes, or entries from the register of names. The number of dead children or elderly people cannot be inferred. Zero deaths versus an unspecified number forms a powerful but asymmetrical narrative comparison.

Comparing the First Epidemic: An Unstated Basis of Measurement

The main prose says the present outbreak was not as destructive as the epidemic of Vimalā's day. This is a comparison made within the prehistory itself. The current chapter does not provide the earlier epidemic's population base, fatality rate, dates of transmission, or distribution by locality. The critic can recognize the narrator's comparative judgement without presenting it as independently established statistics. Vimalā's experience returns as an inheritance of remembrance; this outbreak becomes another opportunity for the community to use knowledge. The comparison suggests development, but gives no individually reconstructed measure of whose suffering was reduced.

The Village's Survival and Individual Deaths: Two Different Outcomes

The final appraisal rests on the claim that "the village did not break." Collective survival and the preservation of every individual life are not the

same result. The deaths from illness make this distinction unavoidable. When Indrāṇī says "we are still standing," "we" designates a community, not an unaltered roll of everyone who had been alive before the catastrophe. The artistic ambition is to name this collective continuity a victory. The critic must nevertheless keep sight of the missing lives inside that assertion. The dignity of communal endurance and the incompleteness of personal mourning coexist.

Indrāṇī Rests by the Peepal: A Circle from Beginning to End

At the beginning Indrāṇī approaches Burhbā with anxiety and exhaustion; after the three calamities she sits by the same peepal. The place remains the same, but the condition of knowledge has changed. Her initial uncertainty —"Can our people endure so much?"—becomes the final declaration, "We are still standing." The circular arrangement makes character development arise from accumulated experience rather than a miraculous change in the heroine. The narrator presents exhaustion and satisfaction together in her eyes. This mixed feeling is more humanly qualified than the song's singular claim of courage, though individual remembrance of the dead is not elaborated in her own speech.

Burhbā's Final Interpretation: The Moral Making of a Story of Trial

Burhbā describes the comet not as the cause of destruction but as "a test." Centuries of accumulated knowledge, organization, and love have had their strength examined. This is the essence of his final speech. The deaths of actual patients do not disappear under that interpretation; the speech gives broad meaning to communal persistence after those losses. "Test" also risks implying that every catastrophe has a purpose, whereas the earlier account of polluted standing water presents distinct material conditions. The narrator offers moral meaning through Burhbā's voice. The critic should not turn natural disaster into a factual act by a conscious examiner.

Knowledge, Organization, and Love: Burhbā's Triad

Burhbā's formulation gathers three kinds of accumulated capital: knowledge, organization, and love. Knowledge appears in the physician and the inheritors of local expertise; organization in the women's house-to-house campaign; and love in the community's responsibility toward those in danger. Love, however, is not developed through many independent relationships: here it is primarily a value expressed in the conclusion. This fresh recurrence of "three" answers the triad of calamities, giving the numerical pattern a rhetorical shape. In [–59], memory had become preparation that could save lives; here it becomes an ideal of disciplined conduct and mutual care. The long novel's

commitment to remembrance thus develops as a succession of communal lessons.

Kabaddi on Every New Moon: Grief as a Repeated Observance

At the chapter's end, the "year of three calamities" is remembered during kabaddi on every new moon. The game is no longer merely leisure: it is associated with speaking the names of those who died and retelling the village's year of suffering. A crisis that happened once becomes a recurring social action, transforming narrative event into institution. The chapter does not dramatize every revised turn of the game, name the players, or specify the order in which the names are called. Its narrator reports the establishment of the practice. A particular year of disaster is linked to the recurring lunar cycle, giving an event in historical time a continuing life in collective narration.

"They Died in That Calamity, but the Village Did Not": A Sentence in Tension

The phrase added to the kabaddi observance—"They died in that calamity, but the village did not die"—is one of the novel's most concentrated expressions of ethical conflict. Its first half acknowledges the end of particular bodily lives; the second affirms the continued existence of the collective village. Neither phrase cancels the other. Tragedy and preservation occur on different levels. It is possible, nevertheless, that consoling the bereaved with the survival of a community may suppress private suffering. The narrator gives no independent protest by a grieving family. The beauty of the sentence rests in that unresolved disproportion, not in an uncomplicated cry of victory.

Protecting Names While Leaving the Dead Unnamed: The Final Inconsistency

The ending declares that a new sentence is added with the "name" of each person lost, yet the prose gives not one name of a person who died in this outbreak. This is a significant gap between institutional practice and readerly access. The community's observance is said to protect names; the reader receives no list. The failure to record six victims properly after the flood in [–89] had already established a related problem. Here the ideal of remembrance grows stronger, while the task of presenting individual identities remains unfulfilled within the chapter. One may call this a literary incongruity, although it would be unjustified to infer from this chapter alone that the names remain absent everywhere in the entire novel.

The Image of Dawn and an Unbroken Sequence of Crises

The song says, "Names survived, courage survived, and a new dawn came again." The prose gives the mixed result of an outbreak controlled within three weeks and some lives lost. The precise day of the "dawn" in the song is not specified; it functions as an optimistic marker in folk speech. In [−59] the dawn brought receding water and zero deaths; in [−58] a new dawn signifies persistence despite the need to remember the dead. The meaning of a repeated image changes from one chapter to the next. The recurrence sustains hope of renewal without erasing the differences among human losses.

The Community's Sound: From Drum Signals to Health Information

During the second flood, the "danger rhythm" maintained by Mohan's descendants was a common language prompting immediate evacuation. The disease chapter does not describe a repetition of that sound. Instead there are the physician's instructions and the women's repeated visits to households. The shift matters: one disaster can be met with an agreed instant signal, while another requires recurring daily communication. Collective learning is not confined to song or drums but changes its means of transmission with circumstances. The chapter does not specify which conversation in which house proved decisive. Its picture of social communication remains largely collective and summarized.

An Environmental Narrative of the Region: Water in Three Roles

Across these chapters water is remarkably multiform. During the fire, water from the pond is a means of rescue; during the second flood, the swollen Kamalā-Balān destroys homes and fields; during the third calamity, dirty stagnant water becomes the narrated condition of the spread of illness. The different sites, states, and uses of water shift across the sequence. River, pond, and pit must not be dissolved into one generic symbol of "water." Each has a separate spatial function. From this perspective, the village never wins permanent dominion over nature. It repeatedly tries to understand changing environmental relationships and devise social responses appropriate to them.

Environmental Causation and the Unequal Authority of Omens

The introductory commentary calls the illness the fulfilment of the comet's third prediction. The main prose, by contrast, constructs a chain of polluted water, bodily symptoms, hygienic instruction, and social intervention. In these two explanatory schemes, the omen acts as narrative anticipation; the water and illness constitute the material setting of events. Because [−61] stated that the comet itself does not cause calamity, making the astronomical sign the origin of disease would contradict the novel's

own words. Nonetheless, anticipation helps organize the story's fear and preparedness. Keeping the levels distinct allows the reader to perceive both the artistic use of foreshadowing and the separate place of event causation.

A Fair Critical Judgement: The Chapter's Dramatic Achievement

The primary literary achievement of "The Third Calamity" is its transformation of the sequence fire–flood–disease from a history of external disasters into a narrative of institutional memory. Indrāṇī's combination of weariness and perseverance, Burhbā's recollection of Vimalā, the town-trained physician, the descendants of Sonmā and Ratnā, and the Women's Night Assembly form a collective network of characters and functions. Having asserted zero deaths in [–59], the novel avoids a falsely simple complete victory by acknowledging some deaths here. The renewed remembrance of the catastrophic year during new-moon kabaddi continues the larger novel's central structures of song, names, and communal utterance. The achievement resides not only in the density of immediate events but in the new functions assigned to earlier narrative materials.

Creative Limitations: The Missing Scenes of Death and Care

The close of the catastrophic year constructs a broad ethics of communal survival, but the private experience of patients, the dead, and caregivers is rarely staged. The physician has no personal name; disagreement within the women's assembly is unshown; the number of deaths is unstated; failures of treatment and the inner world of grieving households are absent. The summary "controlled within three weeks" binds the plot but abbreviates the lived duration of the medical struggle. The song's high ideal of meeting suffering "with a smile" is not fully equivalent to Indrāṇī's exhaustion and the deaths in the prose. The chapter is an effective figure of communal continuity, not a full, fine-grained portrait of the multiple tragedies of illness.

Source Limits, Chapter Number, and the Narrative Ahead

The primary basis of this section is original Chapter [–58], "The Third Calamity"; its opening proverb; the folk song "Three Calamities, Standing at the Fourth"; the account of illness linked with polluted water; the dialogue of Indrāṇī and Burhbā; the participation of the physician and the descendants; the Women's Night Assembly's house-to-house activity; and the concluding sentence incorporated into kabaddi on the new moon. The contents indicate that the original chapter begins on page 284 and [–57] on page 288, yielding an estimated span of 284–287 rather than exact pagination for each quotation. The following chapter, [–57], "The Sahib's

Notebook," raises a new question about the relation between outside writing and the village's own communal memory.

Critical Section 44 | Original Chapter −57 — The Sahib's Notebook

The Prehistory · An independent narratological criticism based on the text of the original novel

The preliminary indication is not an independent measurement of the narrative's actual density of events.

From the Year of Three Calamities to the Contest over Writing

"The Sahib's Notebook" follows immediately upon the point at which the combined year of fire, flood, and disease has entered the village's memory as "the year of three calamities." In the preceding chapters, the overriding question was how to remain alive; here it is who will write the story of survival, in whose language, and who will determine its meaning. The calamities themselves provide the reason for an outside scholar's arrival. The transition from [−58] to [−57] is therefore not an arbitrary change of subject. Communal experience acquires a reputation beyond the village; that reputation invites an outsider's account; and writing then threatens to impose an external definition upon the community. The narrative moves from the right to life to the right of representation.

The Object in the Title: The Notebook as a Narrative Instrument

The title chooses not "The Arrival of an English Sahib" but "The Sahib's Notebook." By foregrounding an object used for writing, it makes the selection of evidence and the location of the observing gaze decisive. The sahib asks questions, writes down answers, and turns those notes into a book. For the world outside, the notebook becomes a carrier of memory; for the village, its restricted selections become a source of humiliation. The conflict is not a generic opposition between paper and voice, but a question of the writer's position. In [−63], small useful books were printed while the great narrative remained deferred. Now a book printed by an outsider poses another danger: the appropriation of communal meaning.

The Opening Proverb: Different Registers of "Account" and "Truth"

"What the sahib wrote was his account; what the village kept in mind was the village's truth." The opening proverb treats the account committed to paper as an individual reckoning and communal memory as truth. Its emphatic division prepares the reader emotionally to distrust the outsider's book. But the novel does not present every memory in the village as identical: Haripati's palm-leaf manuscript, Gangādhar's printing, and the shadow genealogical register are all local forms of written remembrance. The song's opposition is a figurative and political axis, not a rule

established by the narrative that writing is inherently false. Keeping that distinction prevents the work from being imprisoned by its own rhetorical hostility to written records.

"Paper of the Throat": The Song's Oral Manuscript

The opening folk song, "Paper of the Throat," sets the fixed pages of the stranger's notebook against the collective village throat as a living text. Its repetitions contrast the continual coming and going of outsiders with the village's long duration. The substitution of "letters in the notebook" by "names in the throat" establishes a politics of memory: throughout the novel, a name is not merely information but the social existence of the dead or the absent. The song does not, however, explore the detailed circumstances of the outsider's visits and interviews. It pronounces its judgement in advance, while the prose subsequently traces how disagreement develops. These are distinct narrative operations, not duplicate testimonies.

The Succession of the Ritual: From Indrāṇī to Nandkishore

The narrative begins with the brief information that responsibility for the ritual passes from Indrāṇī to her son Nandkishore. A generational transition occupies a sentence rather than an entire paragraph. Indrāṇī was a visibly active leader through the three calamities; Nandkishore first emerges in a dispute about an external interpretation of the community's culture. The ritual continues through inheritance, but the task required of its custodian changes. The narrator gives no separate account of Indrāṇī's later life or Nandkishore's education. That temporal ellipsis accelerates a multigenerational novel, while leaving the personal experience of succession unspoken.

The Visitor's Name: Henry Thompson's Place in the Fiction

Mr Henry Thompson receives a complete name and an interest in the study of popular traditions, in contrast to many unnamed collective figures within the village. His initial purposes are described in terms of curiosity and carefully taking down answers; he is not introduced as a malicious conspirator. This characterization matters because a distorted published account may do harm without a demonstrably malicious intention. Nor may the critic treat Thompson as a historically verified ethnographer on the strength of his appearance in a novel. He is a named visitor within the narrative world. The text does not give a sustained account of his private life or of a subsequent change in his understanding.

The Spread of Fame: The Causal Route of the Story

The story of "the year of three calamities" becomes known in the surrounding area, and Thompson then comes to the village. The folklore travels regionally before it becomes the subject of external research. This chapter does not specify whether that circulation occurred through songs, travellers, manuscripts, or inherited narration; it merely reports the outcome. The compressed transition connects one narrative state to another. It is also important that Thompson is not specifically described as having arrived on a state-ordered survey. His visit is presented as an inquiry undertaken from personal interest. The imbalance of power becomes visible chiefly through his capacity to publish and classify, rather than through an explicitly stated official command.

The Interview Scene: Questions Given, Answers Withheld

Thompson asks what Burhbā, kabaddi, and the channā grove mean. These three questions encompass the novel's remembering witness, collective ritual, and landscape of remembrance. Yet the actual words in which the elders answer, their individual names, and the answers Thompson selects are not reproduced. The reader receives a list of questions rather than a many-voiced transcript of the interviews. The subsequent distortion stands upon this gap: there is no verbatim original response against which to collate each published sentence. The text strongly conveys the experience of insult, but leaves the extent and mechanics of alteration incompletely documented.

A Few Weeks and One Year: The Movement of Narrative Time

The inquiry and note-taking last a few weeks; the visitor departs; a copy of his book reaches the village a year later. Between those points, the stages of manuscript editing, printing, publication, and distribution are not dramatized. Narrative compression makes the production of external knowledge almost invisible, even as its consequences become painfully visible. The novel is less concerned with how the publishing process occurred than with the impact of the finished work upon the people represented. This inequality of duration matters in assessing event density: extensive time receives a few sentences, while a deeply wounded response receives extended dialogue.

The Printed Book Returns: The Reversal of Expectation

Nandkishore is initially pleased that Burhbā's story may reach the world beyond the village. When the printed copy arrives a year later, he and the villagers are stunned. The turning point is not simply the arrival of knowledge but the reversal of hope. Publication was first anticipated as an extension of respect; in its realized form it appears to give permanence to

an insulting description. The book becomes a travelling object: information leaves the village, is transformed elsewhere, and returns to its source. Through this circuit the reader sees that writing does not merely copy experience; it can rearrange the relationship between the source and those who claim to explain it.

Four Derogatory Classifications

Burhbā is designated "a relic of superstition," the channā grove "ghost worship," kabaddi "barbaric customs," and the women's night assembly "uncontrolled social behaviour." Each label redefines one of four institutions of communal remembrance. These are more than impolite adjectives: they sever the practices from the relationships established earlier in the narrative—saving lives, preserving names, giving a hearing, and organizing women. The practices remain the same; the interpretative framework is imposed from outside. The whole of Thompson's printed book is not reproduced. The four selected classifications are the abridged quotations through which the plot generates the village's response.

The Particular Violence of the Comment on the Women's Night Assembly

Calling the women's night assembly "uncontrolled social behaviour" is not a neutral scholarly distancing but a diminution of collective women's work. The reader already knows that this institution helped distribute grain in famine, form the human chain during the fire, and conduct household sanitation campaigns during disease. Earlier narrated actions provide a concrete basis for assessing Thompson's classification. Yet in this chapter the women of the assembly do not make their own public reply to the book; Nandkishore becomes the principal vehicle of objection. The narrative defends a women's institution without giving its members full independent space to speak. That is a limitation of representation, notwithstanding the justice of the objection.

Nandkishore's Anger: The Stages from Injury to Action

Nandkishore moves through four states: happiness at the prospect of outside publication, anger on reading the printed volume, discussion with Burhbā beneath the peepal, and finally the writing of a letter and the compilation of the village's own history. He does not remain a passive recipient of humiliation. Crucially, anger does not turn into violence or the destruction of books; after deliberation, it becomes a reply in writing. The source's uncertain formulation about villagers reading, or having the book read to them, also raises a question of access: how many could read the English text for themselves, and how many learned its contents orally? The prose does not settle that distinction.

Returning to the Peepal: A Site of Communal Counsel

Nandkishore's approach to the peepal repeats the movements of earlier protagonists. This tree has been a centre of conversation during fire, flood, illness, and previous moral crises. Here the threat is not physical destruction but a cultural injury created by a distorted account. The repeated use of the place establishes continuity amid changing generations and changing questions. The village changes, its dilemmas change, but its place of dialogue persists. No fresh miracle associated with Burhbā's residence in the tree occurs here; he functions as a conversational custodian of memory.

Burhbā's Silence: A Pause Before the Answer

Hearing Nandkishore's anger, Burhbā remains silent "for a long time." It would be mistaken to read that silence as agreement with Thompson or admission of defeat, since he goes on to articulate the distance between colonial and local perspectives. The pause checks the impetus toward an instantaneous response, whereas Nandkishore's agitated questions quicken the dramatic tempo. Its precise duration is unknown; the phrase serves as a sign of reflective weight. The long time of communal remembrance and the immediate time of an individual's anger meet in a single exchange. Burhbā's delayed answer becomes the interpretative centre of the episode.

Recalling Haripati and Gangādhar: A Lineage of Writing

Burhbā remembers Haripati's earlier question about writing the narrative in the language and from the viewpoint of the village. Subsequently Nandkishore carries forward the traditions of Gangādhar and Haripati. These references make [−57] part of a long internal sequence about recorded memory, rather than a self-contained dispute. In [−63], publication of the principal narrative was postponed because the story was still growing. Here an outsider's publication alters the meaning of the material. The chapters therefore investigate two different problems of print: the finality of a version and ownership of interpretation. The same medium produces divergent consequences; the novel cannot be reduced to the slogan that books are bad.

Language and Point of View: The Invisible Translation Gap

Burhbā argues that Thompson's eyes, language, and standpoint were not those of the village. This includes a question of translation: how does a social ritual change as it passes into an outsider's scheme of classification? The prose, however, does not distinguish the actual language of the villagers' responses, the language of Thompson's notes, and the precise process used to translate the published book. What is available is a conflict of perspective. The critic must retain this limit instead of inventing

English manuscript expressions or publication details that the primary text never provides.

The Peril of an External Perspective: Naming the Unfamiliar

According to Burhbā, an unfamiliar practice can appear "backward" or "barbaric" through an outsider's lens. The conflict of focalization is thus stated by a character. The novel's reader has already encountered the histories of Haripati, Ratnā, Gaurī, Indrāṇī, kabaddi, and the women's night assembly. Thompson's book compresses those relationships into a few dismissive categories. This surplus of knowledge makes the classification dramatically ironic: the reader knows established facts in the fictional world that the classifications fail to accommodate. Still, the chapter does not stage a fully multilateral village debate about Nandkishore's response.

Nandkishore's Question: Possible Modes of Opposition

"Should I write a letter, should I protest?" In this short question, personal anger opens toward public action. Burhbā does not forbid protest; he affirms it—"Protest, certainly"—but places greater weight upon a sustained programme of writing from within the community. The narrative permits both an immediate answer and long-term self-documentation. There is no formal public debate, printed counter-review, or direct confrontation with the visiting scholar. Nandkishore's action remains a courteous but firm letter and a more careful collection of village narratives. The result is not a victory of international recognition but the beginning of an independent discipline of narration.

The Unanswered Letter: Unequal Rights to Dialogue

Nandkishore sends a polite yet forceful letter and receives no reply. The visitor had exercised the privilege of putting numerous questions to the village, but when the village responds, the exchange falls silent. The narrative irony is sharp: external questions lead to publication, while local objections receive no answer. Yet the absence of a reply does not prove that the letter failed to reach its destination. The story establishes the fruitlessness of the exchange, not a particular act of postal obstruction or conscious suppression by a publisher. The distinction protects an actual imbalance of dialogue from an invented chain of events.

Sustained Collection Instead of a Quick Victory: An Open Ending

The chapter does not conclude with the village winning a public argument. Nandkishore begins compiling its stories more carefully and in its own language. The verbal construction "begins" denotes the start of continuing work, not a completed book. What was a repeated invocation

of the dead in [−58] now becomes the sustained labour of recording social memory. The event changes the village's capacity to describe itself, rather than correcting Thompson's text. Whether the new writings will be preserved must be considered in subsequent chapters; the present narrative does not settle their future.

Collective Voice and One Male Writer

The folk song proclaims that "the village writes for itself," but the main decision is enacted primarily through the two male voices of Nandkishore and Burhbā. Thompson interviewed elders and villagers reacted to his book; nevertheless, the prose does not stage a collective writing assembly or give the women separate testimony for a rival account. The claim to "our own perspective" and the actual centre of decision occupy different levels. This does not make self-representation impossible; it marks the chapter's representative narrowness. The question of how the village's self-description can genuinely become plural remains open.

The Permanence of Print and the Instability of Meaning

A printed object returns after a year, but its representations are estranged from the life understood by the village. Physical permanence of paper is not equivalent to reliability of meaning. In [−63], printing raised a fear that an unfinished living story would be fixed prematurely; here printed classification confronts the community as a direct challenge to interpretative authority. The two chapters form a sustained intellectual and paratextual argument. The text the reader is holding may appear to be one possible account produced against an outsider's version. That is an effect created within the novel, however, not evidence about the author's actual historical process of composition.

The Narrator's Partisanship: Forthright but Limited

The narrator notes Thompson's "good intentions" while selecting the insulting categories of his published book. This opposition is deliberate and narratively effective, but Thompson is not offered the opportunity to defend his book or reconsider his conclusions in direct speech. The outsider's point of view survives chiefly in hostile quoted labels. Because the reader possesses a long background of communal stories, Nandkishore's objection has persuasive force, although the dialogic range of the characterization is curtailed. To note this limitation is not to validate Thompson's classifications; it is to ask how fully the novel allows each narrative position to speak.

Historical Period and the Limits of External Claims

The episode takes place under British rule, but gives no verified historical record of Thompson's visit, publication city, year, or scholarly archive. The proposed audience of "the learned society of England" appears as the visitor's announcement, not as a confirmed bibliographical entry. The internal facts are the inquiries, the promise of publication, a copy arriving a year later, its insulting terminology, the unanswered letter, and the renewed work of local compilation. A history of colonial ethnographic writing might provide useful comparative material, but it is not a substitute for the incidents actually narrated in this chapter.

Narrative Duration: Compressing Several Years

The unspecified period of Nandkishore's custodianship, Thompson's weeks of questioning, a year's wait, and future continuing compilation are concentrated into a very small space. By contrast, the angry conversation with Burhbā is allotted more room. The contrast indicates that the novelist chooses to dramatize the ethical moment in which meaning is claimed rather than to chronicle the entire production history of a book. The characters' silences and objections receive scenic force; the passage of a publication through successive stages is elliptical.

A Mirror-Like Assessment: Achievement and Limitation

The chapter's most important accomplishment is to turn the need for self-writing into an event, at the point where an outsider's printed account distorts the village's own experience. A notebook intended to collect replies instead becomes a means of misdescription; the letter that receives no answer dramatizes an asymmetry of authority. The limitations are substantial: the villagers' responses are not quoted; Thompson's book is reduced to four abusive categories; and the women of the night assembly have no independent opportunity to answer. Thus the many positions composing the "inside" of the community remain less developed than the principle of internal narration demands. The episode succeeds in exposing the tension but does not distribute its voices equally.

"Good Intentions": Distinguishing Motive from Outcome

Thompson appears attentive and interested in his inquiry, and the preliminary commentary acknowledges his good intentions. Yet the published classifications wound the village. The narrative therefore does not attribute every distortion of external scholarship to an evil conspiracy; misrepresentation may grow from an uninformed standpoint. Thompson himself, however, does not respond to the village's criticism. The judgement of his intention belongs principally to the narrator, not to a

developed self-account by the character. The gap between the initially favourable image and the final silence remains an interpretative difficulty.

The Plural Problem Within "Inside"

Burhbā calls for writing the story "from within," but the village's inhabitants do not occupy the same positions of caste, labour, gender, or authority. Can a claim to local self-representation therefore speak for everyone? Thompson questions elders and Nandkishore becomes the leading compiler. The full voices of the women's night assembly, the leatherworkers' quarter, and the descendants of the fisherwoman are not attached to the account before the reader. "Our own perspective" is forceful as a principle, yet still incomplete as a plural practice. Subsequent episodes of writing must be examined to see whether they develop that problem further.

The Notebook and the Earlier Genealogical Registers

The village already possesses genealogical records and a variety of attempts to preserve stories; Thompson's notebook is a new, incoming form of documentation. Their difference lies not merely in size or script but in their responsibility toward the people described. One writer preserves the names of the dead; another calls a practice "barbaric" and assigns it a different social meaning. Yet it would be equally careless to call every local record inherently impartial. The first flood had exposed inequalities in the recording of unnamed deaths. Thus the conflict between inside and outside also opens the broader question of authority within archives generally.

Readers of Publication: Two Communities, Village and Overseas

Thompson promises to publish his account for scholarly readers in England; the village receives a copy one year later. The two imagined readerships confront different effects. The chapter does not say what foreign readers concluded from the publication; it clearly records the villagers' hurt. It would therefore be unwarranted to claim that all of England misunderstood the village. What is narrated is a promise of outward circulation and the result of the printed text's return. The book's passage shows how a system of classification designed for one audience may arrive as injury in the community that supplied its material.

The Selection of Narrative Authority, Not the Verification of Philosophical Proof

The central problem here is not the technical philosophical demonstration of a scholar's propositions but the selection of narrative authority. Whom does Thompson question? Whose answers does he

record? How does the printed text change their words? Does the person objecting have an opportunity to answer? The prose supplies no transcript with which the underlying interviews could be verified word for word. Accordingly the criticism identifies an imbalance of speaking positions while admitting the limitations of a one-sided account. The ethical dispute over external classification is grounded in the novel, but the full text of a supposed original English notebook cannot be invented to substantiate it.

From the Foreign Book to Local Custodianship: The Chapter's Circle

Nandkishore's initial happiness celebrates movement outward: the village's story will reach the world. His final decision directs work inward: the village will keep its history in its own words. The narrative thus traces a geographical circle while transforming its meaning. At first, achievement was imagined as recognition from beyond the community; by the end, it is understood as responsibility for self-examination and transmission. This is not necessarily withdrawal into an isolated localism, since Nandkishore also writes to the visitor. The novel keeps external dialogue and independent local narration in view at once.

Sources and the Bridge to the Next Chapter

The primary basis of the criticism is original Chapter [−57], "The Sahib's Notebook": its opening proverb; the song "Paper of the Throat"; the succession from Indrāṇī to Nandkishore; Henry Thompson's questioning; the book and classifications received a year later; Burhbā's recollection of Haripati; Nandkishore's letter; and the beginning of self-documentation. The contents place Chapter [−57] at page 288 and [−56] at page 292, so 288–291 is an estimated printed span rather than individual quotation pagination. Chapter [−56] places the question of writing in one's own voice in the new setting of a collective political call.

Critical Section 45 | Original Chapter −56 — The Call for Independence

The Prehistory · An independent narratological criticism based on the text of the original novel

The preliminary textual classification is not an independent measurement of the actual density of events.

From External Writing to a Collective Political Voice

In [−57] the village tried to reclaim its story from an outsider's distorted description. In [−56], the question becomes that of collective speech against state power. The right to write was contested before; now public meetings, thread, cloth, and nonviolent resistance become crucial forms of action. "Our own voice" connects the chapters, but the acts performed are not identical. Nandkishore responds through letters and the gathering of stories; in Lakṣmīdevī's time the village enters scenes of assembly, organization, and resistance. An enormous expansion of historical time is brought into view through a single generational succession.

"Call" in the Title: A Process of Collective Communication

"The Call for Independence" does not designate a political achievement already secured; it marks the passage of an appeal. The call travels from town to village, from one speaker to many households, and then develops into organized resistance. Its narrative form is auditory. The reader does not see the day on which independence is achieved in this chapter; the celebration belongs to [−55]. Instead, this title identifies the intervening process: news, fear, organization, risk, and persistence. Its result is not a declaration of national freedom but the continuation of a movement after arrests. The creation of a public voice, rather than a completed triumph, remains its centre.

The Plurality of the Opening Proverb: Rejecting a Single Throat

"The call that reached village after village was not the call of a single throat." The proverb places a limit on individual heroism before the narrative begins. Yet the prose initially gives particular prominence to Rāmāśray's public speech and Lakṣmīdevī's decisions. The song articulates an ideal of plural collective agency, while the prose selects definite centres of leadership. The fact that collectivity is the subject does not ensure equal access to direct speech. Women from the night assembly, younger people, older people, and Rāmāśray take different actions, but their separate private or public addresses are not fully reproduced. The text narrates the

extension of a voice rather than providing a complete transcript of every voice.

The Song "A Shared Call": A Qualitative Multiplication of Voices

One hand rises, then a hundred; one voice begins, ten join it, and eventually the song imagines a thousand throats. The numbers express the growing force of the scene and should not be converted into verified census figures. The lyric's fundamental action is to transform the fear of isolated persons into a collective rhythm. The progression from one to a hundred to a thousand increases the density of its image, while the prose gives no exact count of protesters or youths arrested. To treat such quantities as hard attendance records would collapse the distinction between symbolic folk expression and narrated action.

Generational Succession: Nandkishore and Lakṣmīdevī

After Nandkishore, his daughter Lakṣmīdevī assumes responsibility for the ritual. With this brief statement, a woman again comes to the centre of public leadership. Indrāṇī had led through flood and illness; Nandkishore had safeguarded a heritage of writing; Lakṣmīdevī applies accumulated institutional experience to the independence struggle. The family sequence supplies a long historical thread, but childhood, schooling, domestic disagreement, and the detailed stages of her political awakening are not narrated. Inheritance is a repeated structural device; the changing social work of each successor creates the distinctive meaning of that person's episode.

The Entry of National Events into Local Life: Newspapers and Travellers

News of the Salt Satyagraha, boycott of foreign cloth, and non-cooperation reaches the village through newspapers and travellers' accounts. Written news and spoken communication coexist here, unlike the singular emphasis on the printed outsider's book in [–57]. The local struggle is not portrayed as a wholly spontaneous and isolated occurrence; information about a wider movement provides its context. The precise historical sequence and years of these distinct campaigns are not individually supplied. The narrator compresses several phases of national history into one local awakening. Such compression makes the episode thematically coherent but weakens its chronological precision. Dates absent from the source must not be invented.

Rāmāśray Comes from Town: Reversing the Direction of an Encounter

The English scholar had come from outside to study the village; the young Rāmāśray comes from the town to urge participation. Both are visitors, but their narrative relationships differ. Thompson classified local practices in his book; Rāmāśray asks the villagers to become active agents in a national movement. The comparison shows why "outsider" alone does not determine whether someone exploits or assists the community. The character's actions matter. Rāmāśray's earlier life, political organization, and the timing of his journey from town are not described. His function begins when he addresses the village's public space.

The Speech in the Chaupal: Private Language Becomes a Public Appeal

Addressing "brothers and sisters" in the chaupal, Rāmāśray speaks of the taking of grain, land, and dignity, and urges the adoption of swadeshi. His speech mediates between the politics of a town-based activist and the village's experience. It is an abbreviated call rather than a complete political debate. Nobody in the public meeting is shown immediately objecting or asking about practical shortages, alternative supplies, or the affordability of clothing. Lakṣmīdevī later expresses her misgivings to Burhbā. Thus the speech's potential counterargument is transferred from the public gathering to a more private consultation; a fully dialogic village meeting never takes shape.

Lakṣmīdevī's Fear: The Condition from Which Courage Begins

Lakṣmīdevī wishes to embrace the idea of freedom but fears repression by the British administration. That hesitation prevents her from appearing as a heroine born without fear. The memory of disasters suffered by earlier generations weighs upon her decision: the village has already endured much. Courage arises not because this fatigue is absent but because she decides to accept another risk in spite of it. The narrator gives her fear a place, though not a full record of a village-wide debate. Her decision after hearing Burhbā marks the transition in the plot.

Burhbā Recalls Sonmā: Old Foundations for a New Political Question

Burhbā returns to the story of Sonmā Mānjhin and uses it to frame remembrance and dignity as a response to the independence struggle. He does not claim to guarantee the movement's triumph; he explicitly admits that he does not know how long it will continue or what its outcome will be. His long life does not make him omniscient. The assurance that the name of one who stands for dignity will be remembered, whether that

person wins or loses, transforms the older ritual of preserving names into political remembrance. Sonmā's original story is not enacted again in full here. This is a condensed reinterpretation of the past, not a second contemporary occurrence of the earlier events.

Uncertainty about the Future: Courage Before Victory

Burhbā says he does not know how many years the struggle will last or how it will end. The dramatic importance of the admission is that characters inside the story act without complete foreknowledge, even though the following chapter will present independence. A reader may know the course of public history, but the characters decide while repression and defeat remain possibilities. This is a second form of time in historical fiction: retrospective knowledge cannot be simply placed into the minds of people acting earlier. To suppose that their risk was negligible because an outcome is now known would weaken the fear deliberately constructed in the chapter.

The Night Assembly: From Domestic Hearings to Public Resistance

Lakṣmīdevī uses the experience of the women's night assembly to organize women across the village. Founded in [–66] to hear cases of domestic abuse, the assembly subsequently helped with food distribution [–62], fire protection [–60], and sanitation [–58]; it now enters resistance to the colonial state. The recurrence does not simply repeat an unchanged function. Each crisis gives the organization a new role. Burning foreign cloth is a narrated act, although its date, precise quantity, and the names of participating women are not supplied. A practice of mutual support has become an instrument of political dissent.

The Bonfire of Cloth: A Visible Symbol and an Absent Material History

Foreign cloth is burned as a public demonstration of opposition. The fire differs from the uncontrolled destructive blaze of [–60]; here burning is deliberately made into a symbolic act. The meaning of the same physical action has changed from catastrophe to protest. The prose does not say how much cloth was burned, to whom it belonged, or whether poorer households surrendered items still useful to them. Its cultural force is clear, but its everyday economic cost is barely represented. The episode gives priority to the spectacle of political mobilization rather than a complete account of conflicting material interests.

From the School to Spinning: A New Purpose for Education

Educated youths from the coconut-leaf school learn to spin thread and weave khadi for swadeshi. The school, previously connected with records,

food distribution, and communal knowledge, now acquires a political purpose through productive labour. Education is thereby represented as a capacity to change one's social action, not simply to recognize letters. The occupations, caste locations, economic conditions, pre-existing weaving skills, and actual distribution of garments are not detailed. The novel tells us the direction of collective effort, not the working day of every artisan or the economics of the textile market.

Older Villagers Spread the News: The Movement of Memory

The elders transmit information about the movement from house to house, drawing upon the discipline and patience of kabaddi. The game associated in earlier chapters with death, remembrance, and organization is thus interpreted as an apprenticeship for living political action. Kabaddi is not invoked merely as a symbol; its habits become a narrative explanation for distributing information. Which elder visited which quarter, and how messages passed under possible police observation, remain undescribed. A broad communal competence is asserted, while the intricate duration and risks of its practice must not be fabricated.

Women, Youths, and Elders: Three Divisions of Work

The conflict is not made the deed of one hero. Women organize the boycott of cloth, youths learn spinning and weaving, elders distribute information, and Rāmāśray addresses the public meeting. This division creates a many-part organization. Yet within each kind of work the source does not portray detailed differences of power, consent, exhaustion, or dissent. Women take important organizing roles, while, when the authorities intervene, Rāmāśray and unnamed young men are the prominent people arrested. The narrative acknowledges women's leadership but leaves an unequal distribution of visible risk and narrative attention.

The Internal Tension of Peaceful Resistance

A detachment of soldiers arrives to arrest those taking part in the movement. The villagers offer firm but nonviolent resistance. The prose does not describe blows, a battle, gunfire, or identifiable wounded people. Inventing a violent confrontation would therefore misrepresent it. Nor does the chapter supply the detailed mechanics of arrest or non-cooperation at the arrest scene; it moves rapidly to the outcome. The swift summary emphasizes courage and restraint, but keeps immediate fear, disagreement, and the balance of coercive power indistinct. The event is important even though its depiction is compressed.

Arrest: The Individual Cost of Collective Proclamation

Rāmāśray and several young villagers are arrested. Collective nonviolence now incurs a personal cost: imprisonment enters the movement's otherwise triumphant lyric. Apart from Rāmāśray, the text gives neither prisoners' names nor an exact number, prison location, duration, or treatment. Their release "after some months" compresses the whole interval into a phrase. A history of incarceration could have afforded an extended account of individual fear and endurance; the narration gives mainly the result. The omission is not evidence that imprisonment brought no suffering.

The Leader Absent, the Movement Continues: Dividing Narrative Leadership

After Rāmāśray's arrest, the remaining villagers preserve their organization and continue the struggle. The departure of a named visiting leader now tests the community's capacity to act independently. The folk song's declaration that this is "not one throat" becomes operative in the plot. Still, the narrative does not show who chairs the meetings during his absence, the precise decisions taken by the women's organization, or subsequent demonstrations. Continued activity is reported in summary. The chapter establishes leadership beyond the individual hero without fully depicting the institutions that sustain it.

A Welcome on Return: Heroism in Condensed Form

After some months Rāmāśray and the others are released, and the village welcomes them as heroes. Narrative time accelerates once again: incarceration itself disappears into an interval, and the reception is a brief outcome. Honour arises not from an effortless personal triumph but from the danger undertaken and the movement sustained. The welcome's songs, garlands, location, and exact speeches are unspecified and must not be supplied by imagination. The speaker who had appeared in the chaupal at the beginning returns as a recognized figure, completing a local circuit of social acknowledgment.

Kabaddi Refigured: The "Invisible Opponent"

Burhbā tells Lakṣmīdevī that he has witnessed a "new kind of kabaddi," in which people play against an invisible opponent for their dignity. In earlier chapters, the game was connected with death, memory, and village cooperation. Here its figurative reach extends to resistance against colonial authority. The "invisible opponent" is not a newly invented ghost replacing the soldiers of the British administration. It is a metaphor for the wider and less readily embodied structure of domination. Burhbā offers

a new meaning after the events, not a revision of who actually came to arrest the villagers.

Preserving Names and Arrests: An Overextended Assurance

Burhbā's closing claim that all their names have been preserved without being lost is a collective ethical assurance. The narrative itself does not name the arrested youths, so "all the names" is a statement of the character's ideal rather than a full register available to the reader. Earlier anonymous deaths in the flood [−89] and illness [−58] are not retroactively recorded by this declaration. Here the tension recurs between the author's commitment to preserve every name and the restricted space allotted to individual lives in the prose.

Compressing History: Many Movements in One Wave

Reports of the Salt Satyagraha, Non-Cooperation, and boycott enter the beginning of the prose as part of a single social awakening. The narrative does not distinguish their exact chronological spans, dates, or mutual relationships within the village. This is a technique of historical compression. The long national struggle is reflected in the organization of Garh Nārikela as though forming one wave. The literary movement is rapid, while the separate strategies, burdens, and differences among the historical campaigns remain largely out of frame. The critic must not invent dates omitted from the narrative.

From Fear to Resolve and Struggle to Celebration: The Sequence of Events

The chapter's major stages are news arriving, Rāmāśray's call, Lakṣmīdevī's anxious consultation, Burhbā's answer, the organization of women, youths, and elders, arrival of soldiers, arrests, continuing resistance, and release followed by a welcome. A personal question turns into collective action; Burhbā's concluding words then interpret its meaning. The novel gives an open political conflict a temporarily satisfying local circuit, without claiming that national independence has already been won. This limited achievement sustains the reader's expectation for the following dawn in [−55].

Grief, Risk, and the Implications of Women's Leadership

The song says the village has defeated fear, whereas Lakṣmīdevī is explicitly afraid at the beginning. Together, these levels create a process of change in the character rather than a verified psychological census in which everyone's fear disappears instantly. Although the independent speech of women confronting the soldiers is missing, the earlier work of the night assembly underpins their political participation. The account is one of

broad heroic resolve, with comparatively little room for divergent private feelings. That distribution of narrative space deserves critical notice.

The Audience Becomes an Agent

At Rāmāśray's first speech, the village is primarily an audience. Afterwards, women, youths, and elders turn the words they have heard into different kinds of action. The movement from hearing to doing is the central narrative change. To attribute everything to Rāmāśray's eloquence would diminish the long history of local institutions that enables the response. The outside appeal and internal organization both have necessary narrative functions. At this turning point, however, independently voiced public disagreement is missing; Lakṣmīdevī alone gives extended expression to fear through her private question.

Real Spaces and a Figurative Opponent

The chaupal, the peepal, the night assembly, household communication, and the arrival of the soldiers belong to the described social world. Burhbā's "invisible opponent" is an interpretation offered after the fact. Conflating them would make the colonial administration disappear behind a metaphor even though its representatives actually arrest people. "Invisible" signifies an overarching system of control, not the absence of identifiable police or soldiers. The figure joins the village's old ritual game to political time, but cannot substitute for the real risk of imprisonment.

The Time of Imprisonment and Unspoken Sorrow

"Some months" are crossed almost instantly by the narrative. There is no sustained account of waiting at home, families' access to food, hearings by the authorities, or ordinary days in prison. One can draw an ironic comparison with previous chapters in which waiting itself becomes an oppressive force: here the prisoners' months pass through a narrative blank. Consequently the extraordinary courage of the movement is marked, but its private price remains indistinct. This is a choice of storytelling that the criticism must recognize, rather than silently filling the silence.

Nationalism from Outside and the Village's Older Sense of Dignity

Rāmāśray denounces the seizure of food, land, and self-respect; Burhbā interprets the appeal through the village's memories of Sonmā and other earlier figures. The double movement makes the national idea more than an unfamiliar slogan imposed upon the village: it becomes an extension of locally experienced dignity. Yet this later reinterpretation does not mean that every old struggle was already a national independence movement. The novel can revisit the past and give it new meaning without changing

the political consciousness of characters who lived at an earlier moment. That distinction preserves the chronology of a long historical novel.

Fire, Thread, and Bodies: Transformations of Symbol

Fire was an uncontrolled calamity in [–60]; here the burning of foreign cloth becomes an organized political demonstration. Thread is both a material of household production and a sign of self-reliance. The peepal changes from a site of disaster consultation to counsel about resistance. Objects recur, but their uses shift. Through changed functions the novel establishes an integrated material world. The values of the cloth, the volume of thread, and the experience of paid or unpaid labour remain unspecified. Symbolic association and material action must not be mistaken for a complete account of economic life.

Pre-existing Hierarchies and the Language of Unity

The song celebrates a thousand united voices, but the narrative does not establish equal authority at every level among Dalit communities, women, younger workers, and elders. It does not dramatize a separate dispute about caste representation during this political moment. The declaration that everyone is united is a poetic account of collective intent; there is no textual basis for concluding that earlier hierarchies of power have consequently vanished. The inequalities acknowledged in the following chapter's vision of independence are thus not surprising intrusions but extensions of questions this chapter leaves unresolved.

Source Limits and Critical Evaluation

The primary basis is original Chapter [–56], "The Call for Independence": the folk song "A Shared Call"; the succession from Nandkishore to Lakṣmīdevī; Rāmāśray's chaupal speech; Burhbā's recollection of Sonmā; the women's boycott of foreign cloth; spinning by pupils of the coconut-leaf school; the arrival of the soldiers, arrests, and the reception of those released. The contents give page 292 as the beginning of [–56] and page 296 as that of [–55], making 292–295 an estimated printed span. The principal achievement is the transformation of private fear into collective courage. Its limitations lie in the reduced representation of imprisoned youths' private lives, political disagreement, the precise historical chronology, and the independent speech of women. The following chapter, [–55], connects this process to the historical moment of 15 August.

Critical Section 46 | Original Chapter −55 — The Dawn of Independence

The Prehistory · An independent narratological criticism based on the text of the original novel

The preliminary indication is not an independent measurement of the narrative's actual density of events.

One Scene on a Historical Day: A New Point in the Novel's Long Chronology

"The Dawn of Independence" introduces a particular date into the novel's immense prehistory: the fifteenth of August. After the indistinct duration of news of the movement, fear, arrests and releases in [−56], this declaration fixes the narrative's temporal horizon. The political transformation of the nation takes local form in a celebration at the village chaupal, or public gathering place. The prose does not, however, recount the full national history of independence; it selects the experience of Garh Nārikel. Within this selection, a long historical duration is concentrated into one "dawn," into which the memories of centuries of the dead, of injustice and of hope are brought. The new political moment consequently functions as a point where national and local narrative times intersect.

The Dawn of the Title: New Light, an Incomplete Arrival

As a figure, dawn generally promises the end of darkness; yet the folk song states at its very opening that dawn did not come to every courtyard at the same time. The title's celebration thus carries a critical qualification. The time of national independence is determinate, whereas the "dawn" of social justice remains incomplete. These are not identical measures of time: one is a morning in the calendar, the other a prolonged social transformation. The narrator honours the historical importance of political independence while the song questions the unequal distribution of its light. The episode does not diminish political achievement; it challenges its presentation as a final and exhaustive settlement.

"A Dawn for Everyone": The Opposition Within the Folk Song

Amid the tricolour, drums and festive sounds, the song speaks of a quarter that still lies in darkness. It begins in the language of public joy but immediately introduces a contradiction. Neither the inhabitants of those shadowed houses nor the particular event that prevented a lamp from being lit are named. The image is therefore a collective admonition, not a separately dramatized domestic incident. Its specific function is to remind

the reader of an inequality lying beyond the field of the chaupal celebration shown in the prose. The opening lyric becomes a means of evaluating the limits of the subsequent scenic representation.

From Lakshmīdevī to Vishvambharnāth: A Generation in a Sentence

The responsibility for the ritual passes from Lakshmīdevī to her son Vishvambharnāth. A generation active in the independence struggle is succeeded by one that witnesses the inauguration of a free nation. This succession does not denote the simple inheritance of an already secure freedom: it marks a change in action. Lakshmīdevī undertook political risk; Vishvambharnāth questions the meaning of the outcome. The prose does not reconstruct the intervening years of daily life between the mother's struggle and the son's celebration. Such ellipsis gives the expansive narrative its momentum, but it also removes the personal textures through which their different generational experiences might have been explored.

The Announcement of Fifteenth August: From Nation to Village

The narrative declares that India has become independent, moving from "the whole of India" to Garh Nārikel within that national horizon. The narrator's perspective contracts from the broad political event toward a single locality. This is a familiar operation in a novel that has been building a history of a village across an enormous chronological span. National history is apprehended through one village scene. The prose does not investigate the many contemporaneous regional political circumstances or administrative decisions. Its purpose is to allow the reader to experience the nation's moment through the temporality and institutions of this Mithila village.

The First Tricolour at the Chaupal: An Object Acquires a New Social Meaning

The tricolour is hoisted for the first time at the village chaupal. This object marks a dramatic shift. Previously the public space had received speakers announcing opposition to colonial power; now it displays the emblem of an independent state. "For the first time" establishes the uniqueness of this local event, not a description of a future programme of annual flag-hoisting. As narrative evidence, the flag is a visible sign of collective acknowledgement. Yet the song's question about "every courtyard" explains why one public emblem does not constitute a complete account of changes in every private life.

The Schoolchildren's Voices: The Voice of the Future

Children of the Coconut-Leaf School sing "Jana Gana Mana." In earlier emergencies the school supplied practical education and skills; here it becomes a stage for learning and performing a national collective voice. The children signify both the immediate political event and a future citizenry. The prose, however, gives no named child's response or scene depicting how the song was learnt. The assertion that it sounded "from every throat" produces an effect of communal harmony, not a register of identifiable individual singers. The public concord is significant while questions of class and unequal access remain open.

Rāmāśray's Return: The Historical Fruit of the Movement

Rāmāśray, arrested in [–56], is now an honoured leader in the village. His reappearance makes the local memory of struggle a source of authority on independence day. The reader recalls the risk he previously undertook, so the figure on the platform carries a history beyond this one celebration. But the chapter does not name the other arrested young men or describe their present circumstances. Popular struggle is remembered through a prominent individual, while other participants receive less direct narrative space. Rāmāśray's speech makes clear that independence is a beginning rather than an endpoint, giving political expression to the song's qualification of the "dawn for everyone."

The Agreement Between a Leader's Speech and a Song's Voice

The song declares that independence is not the end of struggle; Rāmāśray similarly says that the real work remains. These two discursive levels converge in meaning, though their narrative functions differ. The song is a recurrent rhythm belonging to a collective voice; the speech is an utterance by a particular character in a particular public moment. The agreement considerably reduces uncertainty about the text's moral position. A critical question nevertheless remains: how many distinct scenes of social inequality does the prose itself provide? The celebration is directly pictured, but no separate household still lying in darkness is represented in detail.

Morning, Evening, Night: The Narrative Time of a Single Day

The flag and song at the chaupal occur on the morning of 15 August; Vishvambharnāth goes to the peepal in the evening; and a celebration addressing the dead takes place at night. These three phases organize the chapter's single day. Public proclamation is followed by personal reflection and then by collective remembrance. The temporal order also forms a development of meaning. Unlike preceding chapters, which compress weeks and years, this episode covers a more bounded span, even as centuries

of memory are brought into the characters' conversation. The difference between the duration of the action and the range of narrated history becomes an important formal tension.

The Evening Visit to the Peepal: Space for Interpreting the Announcement

Vishvambharnāth comes to the peepal at dusk to share the day's celebration with Burhbā. A new political event is once again carried to the novel's old place of dialogue. After the village's public ceremony, one person asks, "What do you think?" The meaning of the state's declaration is thereby placed before the witness's long experience. Yet the opinions of other villagers are not developed into an independent political debate. The conversation beneath the tree becomes the decisive ethical forum. The repeated structure strengthens the village's memory-system while narrowing the scenic range of disagreement.

Burhbā's Prolonged Silence: Centuries Enter a Moment

Burhbā remains silent "for a long time." The narrator describes the interval as though the memory of hundreds of years were being gathered into one moment. Its duration cannot be measured; the silence is an affective device of historical compression. Burhbā was similarly silent before responding to Thompson's book, but the emotional direction here moves from injury toward hope. The same gesture changes its meaning with the circumstances of narration. He does not answer instantly: he appears to search for a point of connection among the many voices of the past.

A List of Persons: An Alternative Index to History

Burhbā speaks together the names of Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Ratnā, Gangesh, Gaurī, Sāvitrī and others. This is not merely a conventional tribute. It links the political dawn of the state to an alternative local history of humiliation, resistance and questioning. Readers who encountered those persons in previous chapters recover whole histories through a brief list. Yet the promise of "hundreds of names" and the small number expressly spoken are not equivalent quantities. The work of preserving names is long and extensive; a single exchange is not its complete transcript.

"The Right to Ask Questions": Redefining an Outcome

Burhbā's central assertion is that the old questions of justice, dignity and equality have not yet all received answers, but that the right to ask them is beginning to receive recognition. Victory is thus recast, not as equality already achieved, but as the possibility of questioning in public. This is a subtle political accomplishment within the novel because it extends the

older obligation to protect names toward a future right of dialogue. The narrative nevertheless does not offer a national survey demonstrating that the new state already listens to every citizen's questions. Burhbā's hopeful interpretation and the measurable reality of social practice must be kept at separate evidentiary levels.

Old Injustices Unresolved: The Restraint of Narrative Heroism

Burhbā says plainly that the roots of caste, gender inequality, poverty and injustice will not be pulled out simply because independence has been declared. The national celebration therefore cannot become an uncritical final triumph. The struggles of Hulāsā, Ratnā, Sukhdev and others are not treated as an empty prelude to a completed history: their underlying questions remain alive in a new state. Yet this chapter does not dramatize a particular contemporary caste incident, woman's grievance or hungry household by name. Such matters function as challenges awaiting future narrative development, not as new incidents that the critic may invent and insert into the present scene.

Vishvambharnāth's "Has Everything Been Completed?": The Dramatic Point of Question and Answer

"Has all our struggle been completed today?" This brief question introduces a tremor of doubt into what might otherwise be the final line of a celebration. Burhbā's answer, "No," opens the narrative toward the future. The passage from the emotional moment of freedom to the prospect of further social struggles occurs through this compact dialogue. One question and its answer establish the need for later transformations. Vishvambharnāth, however, does not himself announce a practical programme. His importance is that of the questioner, not that of the administrative architect of a new state.

The Coexistence of Hope and Fear

Burhbā expresses both fear and hope about what future generations will write. This mixed feeling leaves the remainder of the long narrative open. A figure who carries centuries of memory does not thereby know all the consequences of the new nation in advance. Such an admission of limits brings the magical witness into relation with recognizably human anxiety. In the final declaration, "independence" becomes the name of a new hope. This is a character's inner experience, not the designation of a verified public institution or a foreknown historical verdict. Hope remains powerful without becoming omniscience.

A Gathering Though It Is Not the New-Moon Night: Ritual Flexibility

That night villagers gather spontaneously beneath the peepal, even though it is not amāvasyā, the new moon. A new occasion for remembrance develops without abolishing the established recurring cycle of the kabaddi ritual. The express statement that there is "no kabaddi" matters: not every communal gathering can be classified as the same game. People light lamps, sing and convey the news of independence to the dead. The old ritual place acquires a new use, showing communal culture as capable of creative extension rather than confined to an inflexible repetition.

Telling the Departed the News: The Narrative Level of a Dialogue Between Living and Dead

The villagers announce to the dead that India has become independent. There is no scene in which dead persons answer independently; this is an address by living people through the practice of remembrance. Although Burhbā's magical witnessing belongs to the larger novel, no autonomous chorus of the dead speaks in this celebration. The collective utterance recognizes grief and an obligation owed across generations. "What you endured was not in vain" endows an older struggle with present dignity; it does not establish that full redress has been achieved for every historical death and injury.

Children's Whispers: An Intimate Sound Within the Celebration

After the loud collective songs, children whisper "Listen" to the departed. The shift in sound is significant: public music at the chaupal yields to the fine register of an intimate conversation with memory and grief. The children become carriers of a heritage of names passed down from previous generations. The story supplies neither their individual names nor the particular departed relatives they address. The children's collective voice belongs to a folk-narrative mode, not a set of separately dramatized conversations between living and dead. Its modest sound lends a human touch to the grandeur of the public declaration.

National Symbols and Local Memory: Two Systems of Reading

The tricolour and "Jana Gana Mana" are national symbols, while the peepal and the ancestors' names are emblems of local memory. The chapter places them on the same day, though at different sites and times. The new state's public presence appears at the chaupal; the village's long community of remembrance gathers near the tree. The narrator does not set the two systems in competition. Rather, local questions provide a criterion for judging the worth of national freedom. The song's warning about an unequal dawn becomes more meaningful within this combination. The

legal relationship between the new state administration and the village's own justice institutions is not yet explored.

Declared Historical Fact and a Character's Felt Experience

The narrator announces that "India had become independent," presenting an external historical condition. Burhbā's feeling that independence is a new hope is a different kind of statement: an experience voiced by a character. To conflate them would be a mistake in literary analysis. The public declaration is the time of politics into which the characters have entered; hope is one interpretation of that time. Recognition of the first does not oblige readers to treat all of Burhbā's expectations as accomplished. The novel gives no detailed account of the later constitutional implementation of rights. His "right to ask questions" must not be turned into an unsupported list of specific legal enactment dates.

The Chaupal and the Peepal: Separate Functions of Social Space

At the chaupal are the flag, Rāmāśray's speech and the children's song. Beneath the peepal come Vishvambharnāth's exchange with Burhbā and, afterwards, the collective gathering at night. These movements unite political publicity with a community rooted in memory. The peepal appears twice but performs different functions: first it provides a setting for a private question, then an assembly for public remembrance. Even within a short chapter, the geography of events is carefully arranged. The song's unseen third location, where no lamp was lit, challenges the completeness of these visible public spaces: how many homes did their celebration reach?

The National Song and the Limits of Historical Attribution

The original prose states that the children sing "Jana Gana Mana." That is an event in the fictional source. It does not detail the song's precise contemporary official status, the formulation of a school curriculum or the language of each child's voice. The novel uses their singing as a sign of a newly shared national identity. Readers may research other historical facts independently, but the present critic must first examine symbolic recurrence and the artistic organization of public sound within the narrative. Likewise, "the first tricolour" means the first hoisting at this village chaupal; it is not evidence concerning the flag history of the whole region.

The Unequal Relations of Old Characters to a New Era

Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Ratnā, Gaurī and Sāvitrī came out of different struggles against social and feudal power. Associating their names with one historical national day does not mean that each received complete justice. Their questions remain alive in Burhbā's formulation, and past grievances

become present claims upon rights. The names are brought into one sequence, though the injustices suffered by these individuals were far from identical. The catalogue is a formal device rather than the full story of each life. Criticism must retain that distinct complexity even when considering the effect of their inclusion in one final commemoration.

The Unequal Place of Suffering Within a Collective Festival

The village dances in delight, but the song asks about hungry and darkened homes; the prose provides no separate scene in any such home. As a result, the critique of social equality operates mainly through the song and Burhbā's reflections, less through a particular character's injury. This is an important artistic limitation. Public celebration is visibly grand; inequality is expressed more often as a proposition. The issue remains meaningful, although the reader's emotional investment may become less personal. The subsequent land-reform episode offers the possibility of giving this general concern a more definite social location.

Novelty in Celebration and Repetition in History

The gathering outside the new-moon observance is a singular occasion in the community. At the same time, telling the dead about the life of the living is a reconstruction of the older tradition of protecting names. The new does not entail total rupture, and recurrence does not necessarily mean inertia. The existing form makes room for another event. The particular narrative mechanism does not justify an unrestricted philosophical pronouncement that "history is cyclical." It establishes the more precise fact that ritual time is extended so communal memory can absorb a present political moment.

Page Basis, Achievement, and Artistic Omissions

The primary textual evidence is original Chapter [−55], "The Dawn of Independence"; the song "A Dawn for Everyone"; Vishvambharnāth's succession; the chaupal scene of 15 August; Rāmāśray's address; Burhbā's sequence of remembered names and reflections upon the right to question; and the night gathering outside the amāvasyā calendar. The original contents place the chapter's beginning on page 296 and [−54] on page 300, providing an approximate printed span of 296–299, not page-specific references for every quotation. Its accomplishment is to give the national moment meaning through the village's long suffering. Its limitations include the lack of detailed domestic scenes of inequality, the limited independent voices of Dalit people and women, and the sparse depiction of new state institutions. The next chapter makes land relations a field of concrete narrative change.

Critical Section 47 | Original Chapter −54 — The End of Zamindari

The Prehistory · An independent narratological criticism based on the text of the original novel

The preliminary indication is not an independent measurement of the narrative's actual density of events.

From the Political Dawn to Ownership of Land: A Change in Narrative Direction

In [−55], independence was represented chiefly through a public symbol of the new nation. In [−54], its consequences enter the village through the question of land ownership. The difference between national independence and social justice, opened by Burhbā in the preceding chapter, now takes a specific form. The allotment of title to land, the position of an old landlord's family and the claims of the landless alter relationships within the village. "The End of Zamindari" is therefore more than an announcement of historical change: it constitutes a new phase in a centuries-long story of injustice. Yet the title's apparent finality is not borne out in a simple manner. The narrative itself acknowledges tension and partial achievement.

The "End" in the Title: Legal Abolition and Social Persistence

The title promises a decisive break. The prose makes clear that the zamindari system is legally abolished, but relations of social rank and prestige do not disappear at once. Legal termination and the survival of social hierarchy belong to different narrative temporalities. The apparent completion announced by the title is interrupted when Pratāpsen's descendants show anger and other families remain uncertain. This incompleteness is artistically important because it echoes the declaration in [−55] that independence begins another kind of struggle. The altered village moves toward social justice without claiming to have achieved unblemished equality.

Land and Earth: Two Senses of the Opening Proverb

"The owner of the land changed; the soil did not change." The proverb holds together the mutable nature of rights recorded on paper and the physical continuity of the earth. "The soil did not change" does not literally mean that agricultural circumstances remained static: relationships involving labour, ownership and opportunity have altered. The line offers a figurative grammar for the community's experience of zamindari abolition. Its latter part, "The field knows the name of the one

who tills its soil," affirms a cultivator's moral claim. But the prose says that a "large portion" of land is distributed; it does not establish that every cultivator receives complete title. The difference between folk expression and narrated outcome must be preserved.

"Owner of the Soil": The Song's Repeated Image of Labour

The song "Owner of the Soil" repeats contrasts such as "the paper changed," "the seal changed," and "the sweat remained the same." Labour's continuity makes the new law of ownership meaningful. Guiding the plough and planting seed are material actions performed by the body; papers and seals symbolize institutional rights. The song affirms the ethical correspondence of labour and ownership. The prose, by contrast, presents the operative change largely through a summary of government legislation and land distribution. These distinct modes illuminate one another: the song's relatively assured justice sits alongside a more uneven and mixed account of social consequences in the narrative.

From Vishvambharnāth to Kamalā Devī II: The Recurrence of a Name

Responsibility for the ritual passes from Vishvambharnāth to his daughter Kamalā Devī. The designation "the second" and the statement that she is named in honour of an earlier Kamalā Devī explicitly mark a returning name within the familial line. The same name can recur across generations without denoting the same person. The newer Kamalā witnesses and interprets a different historical task. The novel thus creates a dual rhythm of genealogical identification and changing social circumstances. It gives no extended biography before she assumes responsibility and encounters the political situation. Repetition preserves memory; it does not erase differences between characters.

"Several Years Later": From the Time of Independence to the Time of Law

The chapter places the abolition of zamindari several years after independence, but does not specify the precise year or successive stages of legal notification. Through this indefinite interval a broad historical process enters village life. Supplying a detailed calendar of actual legislation would go beyond the evidence of the source narrative. What the time-marker does establish is that the single day of celebration in [–55] is followed by a protracted process of governmental change. The several phases through which reform might have been implemented are concentrated into summary. This is the compressed presentation of a long social transition.

From Ugrasen to Raghubīr: A Memory of Power

The novel recalls the shadow of zamindari power across incidents involving Ugrasen Thakur and Raghubīr Singh. These references do not constitute a register of government records; they recall named figures of oppression encountered earlier in the narrative. Through them, the reader understands the ethical relationship between older conflicts and the present redistribution of land. Without separately reading every earlier chapter, a critic must not fold all their incidents into one event or manufacture genealogical connections. The primary point is clear: legal change acts upon a structural inheritance of injustice dispersed across numerous earlier episodes. This relation across generations is part of the novel's expansive design.

Pratāpsen's Descendants: Old Power in the Present

The final landlord family is described as descended from Pratāpsen Thakur. The narrative does not present Pratāpsen himself as a living actor in this chapter; it portrays the decline of inherited power. The obligation to surrender land to the government is an administrative outcome, but neither its documentary history nor a detailed meeting of resistance is staged. The former ruling position appears as a group-character. Their bitterness and anger are later reported by the narrator, rather than represented through an extended speech by one descendant. The response of the dispossessed elite is thus condensed into the loss of prestige and disagreement with the new order.

"Most" and "A Large Portion": The Language of Quantity

The landlords surrender "most of the land," and "a large portion" is distributed among landless cultivators and families from the leatherworkers' quarter. These relative expressions matter. There are no acreage figures, total holdings, beneficiary lists or statement of what remained undistributed. It would be wrong to claim either that all land was returned or that every household received an equal area. The direction of reform is definite within the story, whereas its exact scale is not. Quantitative brevity gives the episode its social direction but restricts scrutiny of unequal results.

The Leatherworkers' Quarter: From Flood Vulnerability to Rights in Land

In the first flood [–89], poor protective arrangements made the leatherworkers' quarter a site of social inequality. In [–59], the southern embankment failed again, although preparedness saved lives. Now, in [–54], families from the same quarter are expressly among the recipients of

redistributed land. Across this recurrent geography, land reform becomes more than an alteration to official papers: it suggests the possibility of greater stability in previously insecure lives. The prose does not say that each family received a plot, built a new house, or ceased to face caste-based marginalization. Collective beneficiary status is not an account of every individual's final circumstances.

Sukhdev's Land: The Ethical Fruit of an Older Conflict

Kamalā tells Burhbā that the land Ugrasen had taken from Sukhdev Mahato has now come into the possession of Sukhdev's descendants through permanent legal rights. This report revives the suffering of [−92] and the episode called "Sukhdev's Revenge" in [−64]. Land is not merely a means of production; it becomes the tangible sign of humiliation and resistance transmitted through generations. Burhbā previously interpreted a court ruling as a kind of revenge; the outcome now assumes a more durable legal shape. The narrative nevertheless does not supply the individual descendant's name, the field's precise location or a ceremony at which ownership was received.

The Transformation of "Revenge": From Retaliation to Long-Delayed Justice

Burhbā recalls that Sukhdev's "revenge" had earlier arrived through a judicial decision, whose durable legal form is now visible. Revenge here means neither physical violence nor the destruction of an enemy but the institutional correction of injustice. The title of [−64] is thus reworked by another form of justice. The moving question is temporal: the injury occurred in one person's lifetime, while its benefit is received by descendants. The original sufferer cannot experience direct satisfaction. Burhbā's extraordinary endurance allows the narrative to connect these unequal spans. The time required for social justice becomes far longer than the individual human life.

Burhbā's Satisfaction: The Witness's Role Expands Once More

On hearing that Sukhdev's land has been restored, Burhbā expresses "deep satisfaction." Independence in [−55] offered him the hope that the right to question might gain recognition; here the correction of a concrete land dispute makes the historical value of remembrance palpable. This affective movement extends the witness's role beyond preserving the names of the dead to linking an injustice across generations with its later consequences. Nothing in the chapter, however, says that Burhbā caused the government to pass the law or administered the distribution himself. He remembers and interprets; legal and administrative actions take place elsewhere in the social world of the novel.

Bitterness and Uncertainty: The Counterview of Reform

Landlords' descendants become embittered, older relations grow tense, some families become more self-reliant, and others remain uncertain. These mixed results preserve a residue of difficulty beyond the legal victory. The text does not specify which families suffered how much, whether anyone committed violence, or whether new farmers were subjected to retaliation. The summary gives moral complexity but not a fully developed counter-narrative. At this level, the plurality of experiences through which a law is socially applied remains chiefly declarative rather than scenic.

Kamalā's Ethical Question: The Unequal Distribution of Joy and Suffering

Kamalā asks whether the change is right or wrong, for some people are happy and others unhappy. The question grants a woman custodian a place as an ethical inquirer into national policy. Rather than simply repeating a prepared slogan for or against distribution, she acknowledges the difficulty of judgement in the presence of different consequences. Burhbā distinguishes justice from universal happiness. The novel does not, however, conduct a detailed village assembly on land reform: the value-question is presented through two characters. The dialogue supplies clarity while leaving a wider plurality of class perspectives only partly represented.

Burhbā's "Partial": A Crucial Qualification

Burhbā observes that the landless and the leatherworkers' families gain stability "at least in part." This qualification prevents an excessively triumphalist reading of the story. Obtaining land and gaining social respect are not identical processes; there is no account demonstrating that all conduct toward the beneficiaries has changed. His position that a just change cannot make everyone happy constitutes a moral distinction, but one speech does not prove the wholly impartial implementation of the law. Together, the narrator's relative quantities and the character's "in part" preserve the limits of the accomplishment.

Government Papers and Labour in the Field: Two Forms of Record

The song repeatedly invokes changes to documents and seals, while the prose reports the "legal" title obtained by Sukhdev's descendants. In [–57], an outsider's book had become a source of humiliating interpretation; here an official document is an instrument for correcting dispossession. The comparison makes clear that the novel does not categorically reject written records. The relevant questions concern the power to write, the purpose of documentation, and its relationship to actual labour. Written

form may contribute to oppression or justice, depending on its situation. The documentary motif is thereby given more than one ethical direction.

The Figurative Permanence of Soil and Social Change

The song claims that "the soil did not change," while Kamalā later remarks that "the village is changing." These utterances can seem opposed, yet they operate at different narrative levels. The physical field remains the location, but the relations of ownership, recognized work and available livelihoods change. The novel sets dynamic social ties within a geography capable of carrying memory. If the lyric were read as a literal claim that the environment remained unchanged, the earlier history of floods, fires and agricultural transformation would contradict it. Soil functions as an axis of remembrance, not proof of social immobility.

The School and Possibilities Beyond Land

Over time, a new generation uses the education of the Coconut-Leaf School to seek government jobs, trade and work in towns. Questions of ownership now extend into education-enabled diversification of livelihood. The village is no longer imagined as a closed agricultural society wholly dependent on fields; it shares a changing sphere of occupations. The prose does not identify the youth who obtained a first job, the town to which each travelled, or whether women received equivalent opportunities. Education opens possibilities, but the narrative does not establish that full social mobility has been achieved.

Individual Distress and the Ethical Outcome of the Community

Some households lose land and others receive it. The novel does not deny that reform may produce unequal emotional outcomes. Burhbā distinguishes justice from the numerical sum of individual happiness, his principal ethical concern being the long-standing insecurity of landless people. A narratological question nonetheless arises: the story speaks with confidence on behalf of an historically injured community, but what space does it offer a land-losing household to speak for itself? The narrative recognizes several emotions without developing them into a fully polyphonic exchange. It abbreviates some social complexity in order to articulate a clear moral distinction.

Kamalā's Final Anxiety: The Speed of Change

Kamalā feels that the village is changing, "perhaps too quickly." The chapter turns from the legal event toward uncertainty over social futures. In [–55], Burhbā felt both hope and fear for independence; now the speed of changes under the new state is at issue. Kamalā's concern is not an unequivocal rejection of reform but a feeling of wonder and apprehension

in the face of new forms of an inherited society. Burhbā's reply challenges the myth of historical stasis: the village has always been changing. No measured interval or comparative survey establishes the alleged excessive speed; it is a character's experience of change.

Preserving the Roots: Remembering Names After Social Transformation

Burhbā defines his task not as stopping change but as remembering the names and values associated with it. The preservation of memory is therefore not equivalent to reactionary immobility. To retain a memory of oppressive institutions is not to restore them: the aim is to record injustice and reform alike. The call in [–57] to narrate the story in the community's language and the question in [–55] of who will write the unfinished future converge here. Once social relations have altered, questions remain about who changed them, who benefited or suffered, and whose names were omitted. Such questions must survive for the generations to come.

A Map of Beginning, Middle and End

The episode begins with national legislation and the transfer of a landlord's holdings; in its middle, Kamalā tells Burhbā of the restitution to Sukhdev's descendants and discusses justice; at the end, the narrative summarizes social tensions, new employment and the perceived speed of change. The structure moves from an administrative event through ethical interpretation toward a society in transition. No detailed scene depicts the registration of titles, the first day a new owner tills a field or the procedural resolution of each disagreement. The novel compresses these processes into an alternation of summary and short scenes. The pace serves its historical scope while leaving possibilities for more extensive personal land narratives.

Levels of Narration in Land Reform: Law, Family, and Character

The narrator states that the law has been passed; Kamalā reports the outcome of one particular conflict involving Sukhdev; Burhbā interprets its long ethical significance. These three voices perform different functions. General government policy, a reactivated family history and a judgement about values move from the expansive toward the particular. Burhbā's satisfaction cannot be taken as an empirical survey of every allotment made by the state. His voice offers an expansive interpretation, while the narrative's terms “most” and “a large portion” limit claims about completeness.

Gains for the Landless: An Absence of Individual Voices

Leatherworkers and other landless families receive redistributed property, but not one newly benefiting household is given a named speech. A descendant of Sukhdev is mentioned, yet the moment of receiving land is not described from that person's own point of view. Given the history of the struggle for land, such experience could have had considerable narrative force. Instead the prose concentrates on the exchange between Kamalā and Burhbā. The choice sharpens the articulation of justice as a principle, while withholding direct access to the happiness, uncertainty or apprehension of poor families. They are beneficiaries in the narrative more fully than they are independent speakers.

Land Relations and the Remaining Question of Gender

Kamalā Devī is the central questioner, but the chapter does not separately narrate women's individual property rights, widowed cultivators' holdings, daughters' shares or the gendered distribution of agricultural labour. Raising these issues need not mean imposing an external statute upon the fiction: the novel's earlier attention to the women's night assembly gives grounds for questioning omissions within its own representation. Women's leadership does not in itself constitute a comprehensive account of women's economic ownership. The silence must be identified as an unexamined narrative field, not automatically as proof that such rights were absent from the world represented.

New Employment and the Village's Outward Horizon

Government service, trade and urban employment widen the customary horizon of a land-centred village. This future-oriented summary refuses to treat the local community as a wholly self-contained entity. Persons may leave, while the peepal and its practice of protecting names remain the novel's centre of memory. The text does not yet specify how the later stories of migration and belonging will develop. It offers a list of occupational possibilities rather than the completed histories of particular migrants. That list matters after the redistribution of land: a right to land does not bring the need for diverse work to an end.

The New Role of the State and Older Patterns of Power

In the colonial episodes and Thompson's book, external institutions could exercise power over resources and meaning. Here the “new Indian government” acts through law to increase the possibility of rights for the landless. The state accordingly assumes a different function across the novel. The narrative does not, however, show that government action automatically guarantees final justice. Anger among landlord descendants and the tension of former relationships suggest that forms of social

control can persist beyond formal legislation. The long novel does not simply designate outside institutions as invariably beneficent or harmful; it examines changing results of their actions.

Justice Arrives Late: The Narrative Cost of Time

The return of land taken from Sukhdev is a victory, but the person who endured the original deprivation has passed beyond the time in which he could personally benefit. This ethical cost of delay receives little direct expansion in the celebratory account of reform. Burhbā instead emphasizes generations, patience and the endurance of struggle. The narrative's force lies in acknowledging the disproportion: a result may finally be secured, while the time of the injured life cannot be restored. To allow a happy ending to erase the original grief would make the long duration of the story meaningless. Burhbā's memory sustains the unequal spans of suffering and correction.

Achievement, Limitation, and the Next Narrative Signal

Chapter [−54] achieves its strongest effect by connecting the injustice suffered by Sukhdev with an actual legal entitlement obtained by his descendants, producing a result deferred across generations. The inclusion of the leatherworkers' quarter as a beneficiary joins land justice to its earlier geography of vulnerability. Yet the exact number of allotments, the lives of individual new owners, the landlord family's distinct voice, the everyday use of the land and the persistence of social hierarchy are largely compressed. The primary evidence consists of the original episode, its song "Owner of the Soil," Kamalā's conversation with Burhbā, and the account of land distribution. The contents locate its opening at page 300 and the next chapter [−53] at page 304, yielding an approximate printed span of 300–303. The following chapter, "The First Electric Lamp," will introduce a new relationship between technology and older forms of memory.

Critical Section 48 | Original Chapter −53 — The First Electric Lamp

The Prehistory · A strictly narratological criticism based on the actual text of the original novel

The mechanical proportion indicated in the source is not an independent measure of actual event-density.

Roads, Poles and the Visual Arrival of Development

Chapter [−53] begins at a moment when the large vocabulary of governmental planning acquires visible form in the village: roads, wires, poles and labourers. The "Five-Year Plan" is the narrator's historical indication; for the village children, modernity is the immediate experience of gazing at and touching newly erected iron poles. Thus national modernization and local perception occupy two levels of a single narrative. The arrival of equipment does not itself accomplish the village's total transformation: the narrator selects its first public appearance. We are told neither the number of workers nor the duration of their labour, nor precisely which neighbourhoods the road connected. The concentrated scene conveys the intensity of an arrival, not the entire social history of development.

Harivansh's Generation: Succession and Transition

After Kamalā Devī's death, responsibility for the naming ritual and the Women's Night Assembly passes to her son Harivansh. A major generational transition within the long narrative is compressed into a brief sentence. Harivansh is represented figuratively as holding tradition in one hand while looking toward a new age with the other. The metaphor plants the possibility of inner conflict, although the plot does not unfold a prolonged private struggle. His individuality emerges principally from the question he puts to Burhbā and his practice of keeping an older lamp. The women's institution continues to be mentioned amid this patrilineal succession, but the chapter does not depict any independent decision made by it at this moment.

The First Bulb at the Chaupal: From Communal Scene to Narrative Climax

The arrival of wires prepares the story; the first illumination of a bulb at the chaupal supplies its immediate climax. People fall still, children are lifted onto shoulders, hands are folded, and someone remains standing with an old lamp clasped in hand. These responses form a composite scene without proving unanimity about the new object. The bulb's yellow light

trembles in the water of Dakhī Pond: mechanical illumination is translated into the older visual language of the village's waterscape. Its wavering reflection introduces a slight instability into the image of triumphant brightness. The public moment is vivid, but it is not an event in which electricity reaches every home simultaneously.

An Earthen Lamp Held Amid the Brightness

An unnamed person stands within the gathering clutching an old earthen lamp. This small gesture carries considerable symbolic weight. The village witnesses a new public light, while one individual preserves a familiar object and its accumulated experience. The possibility of resisting oblivion is already visible before Burhbā's explanatory speech. Yet the lamp-holder's name, caste, gender and motive remain unreported. Anonymity turns the response into a broadly recognizable emblem while denying it the depth of an individual household history. The lamp becomes a concise sign of historical feeling, rather than the complete story of a particular family.

The Narrator's Double Valuation of Light

Light is not automatically an unqualified good in the bulb-and-lamp episode. Burhbā observes that illumination produces shadows too. The assertion establishes the double relationship between seeing and forgetting: new means may render the faces of memory clearer, but their brilliance may also conceal older names. Light can therefore function as a medium both of information and of oblivion. The narrator, however, does not present an actual case of a name being forgotten because of electricity. The danger resides in Burhbā's warning about a possibility. An exact reading must distinguish narrated social change from a character's prospective caution; they do not constitute identical kinds of evidence.

Burhbā's Focalization and the Independent Narrator

The coming of electricity is presented initially through the third-person narrator's extensive external view. Harivansh's question then transports the reader into Burhbā's longer experiential time, where the shell-and-string lamp and the electrical bulb can be joined across several ages in a single utterance. This focal shift exceeds the span of an ordinary human lifetime. Nonetheless, the witness's speech is not equivalent to an infallible declaration by the narrator. His concern about shadows is especially a forecast of what might happen. Burhbā's long memory authorizes perspective, but the actual transformation of every household under electric lighting remains outside the narrated experience of other characters. Expansive and restricted focalization coexist.

The Shell-and-String Lamp: The Return of an Early Intertext

Harivansh asks whether electricity will shine more brightly than Burhbā's old shell-and-string lamp. The reference brings back an object from the staging of the opening Chapter [–100], where shell, string and lamp formed part of a drama of perceptual error and knowledge. In the present setting, the lamp becomes an instrument carried through generations of communal life. One object thus crosses from a philosophical scene into the village's technological history. The earlier debate itself is not enacted anew. The mention establishes an intertextual bridge without automatically reproducing all the details of the old argument.

The Song's "Market Light" and the Different Evidence of the Prose

The folk song "New Light, Old Wick" warns against a market brilliance capable of hiding names. In the prose, however, electricity arrives through a governmental scheme; no market middleman appears, and nobody actually erases names. The "market" belongs to the song's symbolic field of apprehension, not to a separate villainous episode narrated in the prose. The song does not demand the rejection of new equipment; it proposes an ethical measure for its use. Its old wick becomes an image of safeguarded remembrance. The prose offers a visible social scene while the song supplies an interpretative value-system. Their relation is productive precisely because they are not identical event records.

Repetition in the Folk Song: Changing Light, Enduring Names

"Light" and "name" recur throughout the song. The sequence moves from wonder at new wires to apprehension about memory, and finally to the injunction that new and old must be retained together. Such repetition makes the lyric a refrain-like instrument of communal instruction; its lines do not each denote fresh incidents. The later statement that Harivansh remembers names beneath the bulb every year can be read as the prose counterpart of this rhythm. Yet we learn neither which names were recited in a given year nor which events accompanied each observance. The formal importance of recurrence is much greater than the specific inventory of events supplied by the text.

"Many Years to Reach Every House": The Interval Within Development

The first illumination of the chaupal is not equivalent to electrification of the whole settlement. The narrator explicitly says that it took many years for wires to reach every house. This brief temporal qualification sets the unequal distribution of access beside the central festive scene. The public gathering place shines, but private courtyards do not all receive the facility

at once. No sequence identifying the earliest and latest recipient households is provided, and it would be wrong to invent a caste- or class-specific order of connection. The interval between introduction and diffusion matters in itself. It also puts the song's universal concern with "every name" under pressure.

Workers Visibly Present, Their Labour Narratively Absent

Workers erecting poles visibly connect the village to the new age, but they are given no individual speech. Their arrival produces the children's wonder; wages, risks, surveying, lodging and the difficulty of the work remain unrepresented. Modernity thereby appears chiefly as a completed spectacle, while the labour required to build it recedes. This limitation is significant within a novel concerned at other points with working communities and their histories. It would nonetheless exceed the available evidence to claim from this one chapter that workers are absent throughout the entire novel. The relevant object of criticism is this chapter's allocation of narrative attention and its cost.

A Bulb That Never Goes Out: Plot Fact or Hyperbole?

The declaration that the chaupal lamp "never went out" after its first night is difficult to read as a verified record of uninterrupted electrical supply. Within the episode it functions more plausibly as an image of enduring public illumination. No power failure, repair or replacement bulb is described. The narrator's certainty creates literary permanence, not a technical dataset about availability. Counterposed to that claim is Burhbā's warning that if the oil in the old lamp dries up, reigniting it may be difficult. One light is proclaimed continuous, while the other demands persistent care. The tension between these figures gives the chapter much of its aesthetic force.

Harivansh's Shoulder Bag: A Bridge from Memory to Action

Every year Harivansh remembers names under the electrical light and carries an earthen lamp in his bag. This small material action turns Burhbā's long explanation into practice. Memory is not confined to an uttered principle; it becomes something that can be borne from place to place. The bag is personal and the chaupal communal, while the lamp connects the two locations and their responsibilities. Yet the text does not explain who fills its oil, how it is maintained, or whether the next generation accepts it. The symbol achieves a concrete present form, while its institutional future remains open.

Pond, Embankment and Peepal: The Conjunction of Places

The first electric reflection flickers in Dakhī Pond, coconut leaves glisten near the village embankment, and Harivansh questions Burhbā beneath the peepal. These recurring locations join the technical novelty to the established fictional world. A technology may arrive from outside, but the characters perceive it among familiar water, leaves and shade. The pond in particular becomes a mirror for the new light, maintaining a material connection with the long aquatic world evoked by the novel's title. The prose does not supply the distances between these sites, the route of the wires or a distribution map. It gives a symbolic spatial composition rather than a complete geography.

The Time of Development: Moment, Years and Decades

The first electric light is concentrated in an evening scene; the coming of roads and poles forms an initial process; extension to individual homes takes "many years." Three distinct scales of time encircle one spectacular instant. The narrator does not assign an exact historical year. The Nehru era and Five-Year Plans are broad historical markers, not sufficient evidence for the date of a specific local project. The fictional chronology is principally the rhythm of transition rather than an administrative calendar. This accelerates the narration but limits historical precision. To replace the unsupplied dates with plausible ones would turn external inference into invented narrative evidence.

Yellow Illumination and the Social Face

Faces shine together beneath the yellow bulb. The scene collects children, elders and anonymous spectators into one public image. Such simultaneous visibility produces a beautiful impression of shared experience, but it does not mean equal distribution of material benefits: electricity reaches individual households only later. The difference between visual equality and unequal access is a central contradiction of the chapter. Separate responses from women and workers are not developed. One scene creates an image of the community while leaving numerous private rooms, resources and lived inequalities outside the frame.

Burhbā's Laughter: Dispelling a Simple Fear of Technology

Harivansh suspects that the greater light will render the old lamp irrelevant. Burhbā laughs and answers that no form of light appears old to him. His laughter interrupts a simplistic hostility between past and present. The long-lived guardian of memory is not the enemy of change; he asks what its use will mean. Yet the answer subsequently becomes cautionary: brilliance may also dazzle people until names disappear from view. Acceptance, doubt and the will to protect thus form a miniature

progression in the character's thought. He is not merely a fixed emblem of tradition, but a reflective presence whose position develops within the dialogue.

Which "Old" Things Should Survive? The Problem of Selective Memory

The chapter advocates keeping an old earthen lamp, but does not claim that every institution of the past was just. Previous chapters have described zamindari, caste inequality and other abuses. Preserving the names of the past and reinstating past injustice cannot be treated as identical goals. Harivansh's carried lamp does not itself elaborate this distinction, but the novel's prior history of struggles for justice makes it necessary for the reader. Such selectivity prevents criticism of modernity from becoming an unthinking longing for former hierarchies. The prose does not provide an explicit philosophical catalogue of which inheritances must be saved or rejected; the distinction must remain a responsible reading, not an added episode.

The Public Renewal of the Ritual

Harivansh continues to remember new names beneath the electric light at the chaupal every year. Technology does not end the older observance; the observance makes the new technology part of its public setting. "Every year" gathers many similar actions into a single iterative statement, rather than displaying a separate scene for each occasion. Dates and attendance figures are not provided. Nevertheless, a consequential transition occurs: the bulb begins as an object of collective astonishment and becomes part of an institution when names are recited beneath it. The shift is a matter of narrative function as much as technological arrival.

The Visual Paradox of "Making Names Visible"

Names ordinarily inhabit voices, memory, leaves and written pages; light does not literally turn them into separate visible bodies. Burhbā's wish for a light "that makes names visible" therefore translates social recognition into an optical metaphor. It calls for bringing neglected people into public notice. Whether the lamp renders every name equally present remains an open question. This chapter does not dramatize the rediscovery of a particular forgotten individual. The ethical goal is bright, while its narrated accomplishment is more limited: Harivansh performs regular remembrance, but the complete elimination of historical invisibility has not been shown.

The Song's Warning and the Celebratory Ending

The lyric repeatedly warns about the hazards of new illumination, while the prose ends with astonishment, Burhbā's accommodating response and Harivansh's annual commemorations. The ending is affirming. Yet the long delay before domestic electrification and the continuing need to carry an earthen lamp prevent the warning from becoming meaningless. The episode combines an apparently successful moral instruction with a limited demonstration of practice. The resulting judgment is not that modernity achieves an effortless victory, but that it becomes the subject of an ongoing conversation with inherited symbols. Its social costs remain much less fully represented.

The Changing Significance of Light Across the Trilogy

From the shell-and-string lamp to destructive fire, the Women's Night Assembly's lamp of justice and the electrical bulb, illuminated objects have repeatedly changed their work. Chapter [–53] adds an explicitly technological layer to that sequence. The subsequent chapter concerned with radio and television will move the issue of illumination into the public hearing and viewing of mediated events. The bulb thus anticipates a continuing change in forms of communication, rather than standing alone as an industrial milestone. No complete theory of all media in the trilogy can be established from this chapter in isolation; its significance must be tested through those later uses.

Final Evaluation and Limits of the Source

The strengths of "The First Electric Lamp" lie in its connected visual sequence: communal wonder at the chaupal, light trembling on the pond, the anonymous holder of an earthen lamp, Burhbā's laughter, and Harivansh's lamp carried in a bag. The prose proposes a practice of remembrance alongside new equipment, rejecting both blind enthusiasm and blanket rejection. Its limits are the abbreviated treatment of line-workers, unequal household connection, actual daily uses of electricity and effects upon private lives. The following Chapter [–52] takes the question of voices, war and remembered names into another sphere. This judgment is based on the narrated episode and its lyric, not on a reconstructed technological history absent from the text.

Critical Section 49 | Original Chapter −52 — The Call from the Border

The Prehistory · A strictly narratological criticism based on the actual text of the original novel

The mechanical proportion indicated in the source is not an independent measure of actual event-density.

News from the Border: Distant Events Within a Local Narrative

In “The Call from the Border,” war occurs principally outside the village, yet reports of it enter the village's social life. Fighting toward China is mentioned first and toward Pakistan afterwards. The narrator offers no operational history of the campaigns, military strengths or detailed accounts of victory and defeat. The radio's faint voice and conversations in the market connect geographically separated places. National conflict is translated into a rural experience of departure, waiting and remembrance. The years 1962 and 1965 are explicitly supplied, but exact dates for each villager's actions are not. What the novel chronicles is the impression left on local lives, not a comprehensive history of the wars.

From Plough and Fishing Net to Uniform: A Change in Bodily Role

Young men whose hands previously worked ploughs and fishing nets now put on uniforms and depart for the frontier. One figure compresses the transformation from agricultural and fishing labour into the role of the soldier. It signifies a sharp change of identity rather than a complete account of these occupational groups. The continuing cultivation of fields, the hardships faced by those left behind and the process of recruitment are not narrated independently. The collective “young men” acquire a partially individualized form through Vijaykumār, Rāmāśray's grandson. His named trajectory gives some human specificity to a larger category that otherwise remains generalized.

Vijaykumār: A Link Between Familial Memory and National Conflict

Rāmāśray was associated with imprisonment and resistance during the independence struggle. His grandson Vijaykumār's military service represents another generation's engagement with national events. This link brings the earlier independence movement and later border wars into dialogue through one family, but does not establish that the two conflicts are ideologically identical. The soldier's father, family finances, inner motivations and full recruitment story are not given. Vijaykumār's life is organized into four brief phases: farewell, injury in war, return and

remembrance of a companion. The personal freedom and complexity of his political thinking remain comparatively undeveloped.

The Night of Departure: Samadāun and the Mother's Perspective

Women apply a ceremonial mark to Vijaykumār before his departure, while his mother covers her face with her sari's end and cannot suppress her samadāun, a song of parting. The song "Border and Sohar" brings the sounds of farewell into contact with a traditionally birth-associated song. The contrast joins life's beginning to departure shadowed by the possibility of death. The mother has no personal name in the narrative, although her bodily gesture renders her emotion vividly present. She is not shown participating in the military decision; she is represented through apprehensive waiting. The difference raises a question about whether the national narrative gives women independent lives or primarily the role of accompanying and mourning male action.

Radio, Market and the Collective Time of Waiting

During the war, reports heard on the radio become the leading topic at evening gatherings in the chaupal. These reports are signs of distant events rather than the events themselves. Families cannot know everything happening at the front and live amid incomplete information and fear. The description "neither entirely fear nor entirely pride" catches this unsettled state precisely. Radio brings distant space into the village's time of conversation without erasing the absence of direct experience. Suspense comes from a prolonged wait and uncertain outcome. Battle scenes remain outside the narrative field, which instead follows the social life of their transmitted news.

The Silence of a Household: The Private Form of Absence

In households that have sent a son to the border, the courtyard is filled with a deep silence. It represents more than the absence of noise: it is a condition in which the result has not yet been decided. Public discussion continues audibly at the chaupal, while the domestic courtyard remains comparatively mute. This private-public contrast develops distinct emotional registers of war. Rather than opening a long interior monologue by the mother, the narrator composes her state from external signs. The national language of martial honour and the local language of apprehensive maternal grief coexist, but the text does not resolve them into a single undifferentiated sentiment.

The Women's Night Assembly: Safeguarding Names Before Loss

The women remember separately the names of young men who have gone to war. The significance is that names are guarded while the men remain

at risk, not solely after death. The witnessing tradition expands from retrospective commemoration toward a form of anticipatory social care. The number of soldiers, families and precise procedure for reciting their names is not given. Nevertheless, the assembly's reappearance links the episode to the long history of communal institutions. The women's collective voice gives shared expression to private fear, although individual members are not accorded extended independent speeches.

Burhbā's Memory Across Borders

Burhbā observes that bodies travel toward the frontier but names return toward the village that remembers them. His long-lived memory distinguishes geographical location from enduring social relationship. The moral claim does not apply solely to people dying within the village. References to far-off mountains and deserts expand the story's imagined geography. They do not, however, identify particular deaths at verifiable places or document specific battles there. The direct narrative examples remain Vijaykumār's wounded return and his recollection of a fallen companion. The broader geography serves an explanatory and symbolic function rather than supplying a military map.

From 1962 to 1965: The Technique of Temporal Compression

Several years and two wars are traversed in a small number of lines. The narrator selects two historical dates without translating the interval into a sequence of daily private lives. The outcome is concentrated in Vijaykumār's injury in 1965, followed by "months" of treatment summarized briefly. An instant of departure, prolonged waiting and long treatment occupy markedly different narrative durations. The chapter thus touches a large historical span while offering a more selective sequence of changes in feeling than in military facts. The arrangement is effective but places actual moments of combat largely out of view.

A Wounded Return: History Written Into the Body

Vijaykumār returns with one weakened arm. Celebration at his survival is complicated by a lasting physical mark. The result of war cannot be divided simply into death and wholly unharmed return. Yet the chapter does not narrate the daily labour of an injured former soldier, his subsequent finances or how a weakened arm affects farming and fishing. This absence limits the social history of bodily injury. Even so, one precise physical detail differentiates Vijaykumār from a generic patriotic emblem. He becomes a living witness capable of carrying the memories of others.

Harivansh's Fear: Another Meaning of Joining the List

Harivansh had feared that Vijaykumār's name would join Burhbā's "list," as though inclusion necessarily signified death. Burhbā corrects this: he remembers all the young people who have gone to the border, not only the dead. The dialogue changes a supposed death register into a cultural record of living and dead alike. This minor semantic correction is the chapter's central intellectual event. Memory acknowledges risk while a person is still alive. The prose does not show whether the "list" is a physical document or a figure for Burhbā's internal remembrance, so the critic must leave its material form unresolved.

The Companion Who Did Not Return: An Absent Presence

Vijaykumār repeatedly tells children stories of the frontier and ends by recalling, by name, a companion who stood beside him and fell. The companion never speaks directly in the chapter, yet becomes indispensable to its repeated telling. Crucially, the prose does not disclose his name to the reader, even while saying that Vijaykumār included it. Here the commitment to preserving names produces an artistic discrepancy: naming is affirmed within the fictional practice, while a particular individual remains unnamed in the published narration. The distinction between the social function of remembrance and the incompleteness of personal biography should not be disguised.

Children as Listeners and the Next Cycle of the Ritual

Vijaykumār's recurring accounts make children the next recipients of the village's war memories. The closing repetition of the fallen companion's name turns listening into potential participation in a tradition. No individual retelling is rendered separately: "every time" gathers many occasions into an iterative summary. National military experience is thereby carried across generations. Narrative attention also moves from Burhbā's durable memory toward a living man's transmitted voice. Burhbā remains the background keeper, while Vijaykumār becomes a mobile source of experience. The children's later reactions, choices and disagreements are not supplied.

Samadāun, Sohar and Names: A Combination of Song-Meanings

The song has the body cross the frontier while the name remains in the village. Joining the music of sohar to the sorrow of samadāun produces a striking tension between birth and separation. The mother's farewell song is a narrated event, but the prose does not show a sohar sung in every household bereaved by war. The lyric's image of obeisance on "both leaves" is likewise a general emblem; no specific writing of a name onto two leaves is narrated. Such distinctions reveal the difference between the lyric's

poetic work and a literal sequence of events. The song establishes an emotional relationship among distance, departure and remembrance.

The Border and the Nation: The Narrator's Chosen View

The prose shows reports from war reaching an Indian village. Enemy soldiers, civilians at the frontier and political deliberation behind military decisions receive no autonomous voices. This is a consequence of the chapter's local focalization. One cannot derive from that absence a complete moral adjudication of the wars. The narrator emphasizes mothers, wounded youths and communal acts of remembering over a governmental or strategic narrative. The choice illuminates human costs, but it also leaves the experience of the other side invisible. Polyphony remains partial.

Burhbā's Instruction Versus Vijaykumār's Experience

Burhbā says that names do not recognize borders; Vijaykumār speaks of snowy mountains and nights on guard. The first is an enduring moral aphorism, the second an embodied recollection of a particular kind of place. Their conjunction prevents the chapter from becoming pure sermon. Yet the veteran's account is not reproduced as an extended first-person memoir: the narrator summarizes it. His experience consequently substantiates the ritual of remembrance more than it forms a separately realized soldier's autobiography. The difference in discursive authority is important when assessing the actual density of narrated events.

War Memory and the Novel's Original Promise of Water Burial

The recurring proposition that a crocodile may take a body but cannot take a name is extended from deaths in water to deaths and injuries along distant borders. Where water and crocodiles were the earlier threats to bodily existence, war now provides another occasion for preserving names. The repeated image thus changes its social purpose, rather than merely reiterating the same sentence. But the elaborate system of practical life-saving preparations seen in flood chapters is not developed here. Burhbā acts as a guardian of memory, not as a supernatural agent able to prevent war. This restraint supports the consistency of his cultural function.

Maternal Pain and the Unequal Language of Heroism

The village welcomes Vijaykumār back, but the mother whose farewell was so affecting does not receive a comparably detailed return to her perspective. At the beginning her covered face, song and apprehension carry the emotion; at the end the soldier's stories and the children's listening dominate. Male transmission of military memory becomes highly visible while the mother's sustained anxiety and care recede. The

difference concerns the narrator's distribution of attention, not merely a missing item in a list of topics. The assembly's collective remembrance provides a partial counterweight, but does not develop the individual mother's own subsequent narrative.

Narrative Achievement: Turning War Into an Intimate History of Names

The chapter's achievement is to carry the immense external event of national war into the village's household, chaupal, women's assembly, weakened arm and listening children. The decisive battles happen elsewhere; readers experience them through consequences and recollection. This indirection creates an atmosphere of fear, waiting and remembrance. The price is the absence of major political and military episodes and the failure to disclose the fallen companion's name. The chapter is not a full revisionist account of political history, but an intimate extension of the village's memory-world, and should be assessed in those terms.

Source Indications and the Next Connection

The direct basis is original Chapter [–52]: the border conflicts of 1962 and 1965, Vijaykumār's wound, the Harivansh–Burhbā exchange, and the recurring stories told to children. The prior plan gives 494 word units and 23.1 per cent action-indicating paragraphs; neither figure independently establishes event-density. Sohar and samadāun are important to the original song's two contrasting sound worlds, but each lyric line must not be converted into a separate incident. The following Chapter [–51] turns from the frontier to the field, new seed and market goods, and the possible loss of inherited knowledge. Both ask what should be preserved when familiar forms of life become vulnerable.

Agricultural Time Left Behind by War

Young men leave ploughs and nets for military uniforms, but the prose does not tell us who transplants crops, maintains the fishing economy or supports dependent households during their absence. The omission matters because national obligation and local livelihood place simultaneous claims on the same bodies. Maternal waiting is explicit, whereas the redistribution of economic work among generations remains unseen. One cannot conclude that every villager made an identical sacrifice. The costs of changed bodily roles are left incomplete while the preservation of names is made the central achievement.

The Narratorial Gap Between Departure and Return

After Vijaykumār's farewell mark, the prose leaps to an aggregated account of war and months of treatment. The omission speeds the story but leaves the precise wounding scene, conversations at the hospital and domestic response untold. The reader bridges the missing journey through the family's waiting. This gap strengthens the relation between the fear audible in the farewell song and the fact of a wounded return, while giving limited autonomy to the soldier's experience of combat. Narratologically, this is an effect of selection and ellipsis, not a licence to reconstruct missing historical events.

The Possible Inheritance of War Memory and Unanswered Questions

Children hear the wounded soldier's accounts, but the narrative does not disclose whether those listeners later develop views about peace, nation, remembrance or the ethics of warfare. Might Vijaykumār's stories teach a form of patriotism, a fear of violence, or both? The text leaves the issue to the reader. Burhbā promises that names will outlast death; he does not undertake a critical inquiry into the causes of war. Identifying such open questions maintains analytical precision. It does not authorize an invented address, debate or future decision absent from the original.

Critical Section 50 | Original Chapter −51 — The Seeds of the Green Revolution

The Prehistory · A strictly narratological criticism based on the actual text of the original novel

The mechanical proportion indicated in the source is not an independent measure of actual event-density.

New Seeds: Market Goods and a Turning Point in the Village Story

"The Seeds of the Green Revolution" opens with high-yielding varieties and sacks of chemical fertilizer arriving in the village. National agricultural change becomes visible through heavy, bending rice ears and heaps of grain on the threshing ground, rather than through a speech about government policy. The new seeds come through the market, but the story does not follow their sellers, prices, subsidies, credit arrangements or purchasers. Productivity appears as a visual accomplishment, while the power relations involved in obtaining the goods remain obscure. Readers immediately perceive an abundance of food, but not a complete account of how its economic benefits are distributed. The market object begins a social transformation rather than proving that progress is complete.

Heavy Rice Ears and a Shadow of Double Meaning

The rice ears bend because their grain has grown so heavy. This is a concrete image of prosperity. Almost immediately, however, the narrator says that inherited knowledge begins quietly to disappear under the shadow of the new harvest. One agricultural image thus contains two opposite movements: an increase in food and a decline in available tradition. "Shadow" becomes a narrative device for a loss occurring inside a visible achievement, rather than merely a botanical feature. The text does not condemn the new seed as useless; it expressly recognizes the reduction of hunger as a benefit. Its criticism juxtaposes gain and the narrowing of alternatives, even where the loss of old knowledge is summarized rather than dramatized through particular farmers.

Sunaynā: The Successor's Independent Question

Harivansh's daughter Sunaynā asks Burhbā what it means for food production to grow while older varieties disappear. Her question introduces the next generation of female custodianship as active inquiry, not merely the receipt of an inherited ceremonial office. Burhbā gives language to the danger of losing options, but Sunaynā herself performs the decisive actions: collecting seed and sowing it repeatedly. The sequence of question, conversation and work constitutes a complete miniature

character arc, linking her to earlier women who converted memory into practical organization. Her private biography remains compressed, but her authority to identify a problem and act upon it is explicit.

Acknowledging the Benefits of Innovation: No Automatic Rejection

Burhbā plainly acknowledges that more grain and a reduced danger of hunger are good. The opening prevents an inflexible opposition between modern science and old custom. The conflict is not with the existence of new means, but with the total extinction of older seeds and the options they embody. The novel thus poses a problem of productivity alongside resilience and choice. Yet it gives no numerical yield comparisons, experiments in soil chemistry or controlled trials establishing the performance of varieties. Such propositions remain within the experience and memory of the fictional community. They should not be restated as laboratory findings or universal agricultural conclusions.

Seeds as a Metaphor for Memory: More Than Grain

Burhbā describes seed as a store of communal memory: ancestors, famine, rain and encounters with the soil lie dormant within the small grain. This does not mean literal written history sealed inside a seed; it is the poetic transformation of practical knowledge transmitted through selecting, growing and preserving varieties. A generation keeping seed also safeguards some of the possibilities available to those yet unborn. The novel's central concern with inscribed or spoken names is transferred into living, reproductive matter. Material continuity and social memory become closely related, but should not be mistaken for literally identical processes.

Ratnā's Descendants: The Transmission of Expertise

Ratnā's descendants are presented as keepers of older soil knowledge, varietal diversity and inherited understandings of resistance to plant disease. The narrative respects their expertise without naming the particular descendant who can identify each variety or showing the procedures through which that knowledge was tested. Expertise is therefore associated with a collective family inheritance more than with independently developed specialist characters. Through their collaboration with Sunaynā, this inheritance becomes an active part of constructing a seed store rather than a purely nostalgic recollection. Links with older scenes of herbal, riverine and environmental knowledge are meaningful, but some are made in the narrator's summary instead of in separately enacted encounters.

The Grandmother's Recollection: Something Already Lost

Sunaynā recalls an old rice variety described by her grandmother: it yielded less grain but was known locally not to rot in floodwater. This brief act of recollection gives the present argument a recognizable voice from family experience, though the grandmother does not reappear in a new dialogue scene. The claim that the particular rice is now absent from every field sits alongside a later plan to preserve surviving older seeds. They can be reconciled if one named variety is lost while other traditional varieties remain; however, the prose does not fully distinguish those categories. A careful translation must preserve the ambiguity, not make the vanished variety magically available again.

Flood-Tolerant Rice: The Return of the Water-History

The value of the old rice is defined through experience with flooding. The agricultural chapter is consequently interwoven with the novel's long narrative of water, rather than being restricted to Green Revolution economics. Flood Chapter [–59] and the earlier famine episodes form the experiential background for Sunaynā's concern about future hazards. The text does not establish that every old variety is better adapted than every modern one. One remembered example provides a reason for retaining several options, not for declaring inherited agriculture universally infallible. The distinction is important to the chapter's balanced view of innovation.

The Earthen Jar: A New Form of Archive

Sunaynā stores older seeds in earthen jars in a corner of the channā grove. Like the shadow-register, palm-leaf manuscripts, printed books and Burhbā's memory, the jar is a repository. Unlike many written records, however, its contents can be planted and reproduce themselves. Paper is read; seed must be cultivated. Memory thus becomes a future-directed biological practice. The earthen container also gives storage a modest, tangible scale. The chapter does not specify humidity controls, quantities, preservation techniques or a complete inventory, and it should not be recast as a technical description of a modern seed bank.

A Handful at Every Planting: Preservation Through Repeated Action

Each planting season, Sunaynā removes a handful from the jar and grows older rice in a small plot along the edge of the field. This is the chapter's decisive action. Seed is not left forever enclosed: it participates in another cycle of living growth. “At every planting” is an iterative account, summarizing work undertaken over successive seasons. The grandmother's knowledge passes through Sunaynā's present labour toward the possibility of another generation, but the text does not show that a named successor

continues the practice. The commitment has become an embodied act; its ultimate future remains open.

The Channā Grove: From Place of Remembrance to Place of Seed

A quiet corner of the channā grove becomes a seed repository. Earlier the place held stories, the game of kabaddi, the names of the dead, assemblies and the experience of natural disasters. Now it safeguards options that future farmers may need. This new function is a structural achievement of the expansive novel: recurring geography answers changing human needs. Yet the account does not identify legal ownership of the jar, formal custodians, distribution rules or the participation of a farmers' assembly. The grove is an effective symbolic and practical location, not a fully detailed institutional blueprint.

Along the Edge of the New Field: A Composition of Centre and Margin

Older rice occupies a small plot at the margin of a larger field of new seed. The spatial arrangement is meaningful. Current large-scale production dominates the centre while remembered alternatives occupy a narrow but living edge. Marginality does not necessarily signify insignificance: the edge may be precisely the minimum place in which another future survives. Through local soil, jars and rice grains, the author gives a visual geography to the argument. Whether such a small planting can preserve long-term diversity is not answered by measurement; the symbol is lucid, while its practical adequacy remains untested.

The Song's "Old Seed Does Not Rot in Floods": The Problem of Generalization

The folk song celebrates older seed as remaining firm through floods. The prose supplies a remembered instance of one flood-tolerant rice variety, not evidence about every locally inherited seed. The lyric's collective generalization urges preservation, but cannot serve as scientific proof of universal tolerance. Respecting that limit does not lessen its aesthetic function. It clarifies the different work done by the song's expansive reassurance and the narrative's specific recollection. Since the prose also depicts substantially higher yields from new seed, complete distrust of innovation is not the only available interpretation.

Yield and Options: Present Time and Future Time

New seed reduces current hunger; old seed is retained as a possible aid to future adaptation. The real tension lies between these temporal horizons. Burhbā, whose life spans a seemingly exceptional historical duration, uses remembrance not to demand a return to the past but to guard against

foreclosing the future. Sunaynā gives that argument the form of a continuing practice. A successful harvest in one year is not a guarantee that all future conditions will be identical. Nevertheless, no new famine is narrated here as the actual consequence of lost varieties: future vulnerability remains a possibility considered by the characters.

Fertilizer Is Named, but Where Is the Soil's Reaction?

Sacks of chemical fertilizer appear explicitly in the chapter, but the prose provides no separate scene depicting their environmental effects. Soil degradation, polluted water, debt spirals or new plant diseases must not be supplied as though they are narrated facts. The primary focus is the threatened disappearance of seed varieties. This allocation creates a limit: several possible controversies surrounding the Green Revolution are concentrated in one emblem, the older seed. The narrowed focus also gives the brief episode a clear emotional centre. Criticism should recognize both the efficiency and the representational incompleteness of that selection.

Heaps of Grain and Farmers Out of View

Farmers rejoice in the harvest, but the novel gives no household-by-household account of who obtained the new seed, which fields benefited, or how added grain was shared. A general scene presents agricultural abundance. The preceding Chapter [−54] mentioned new land rights for the previously landless, so the sequence suggests a wider communal transformation, but does not follow any particular beneficiary family across the two chapters. Its account of improved production is internal to the fictional village. It must not be converted into an externally verified economic dataset simply because the Green Revolution is a historical subject.

Sunaynā's Work and Burhbā's Speech: Their Relative Weight

Burhbā explains the meaning of inherited seed in a proverbial register; Sunaynā establishes an actual store and carries out planting. Narrative energy therefore moves from a mentor's abstract speech to tangible activity. Finding seed, storing it in an earthen jar and setting aside a strip of land form a compact sequence of actions. Sunaynā is not a passive hearer of instructions. At the same time, fuller dialogue about agreement, objections and labour among Ratnā's descendants could have produced a more polyphonic account of collective decision-making. The existing prose favours decisive movement over extended social deliberation.

The “Disappearance” of Older Knowledge: Narrator and Character

The narrator reports that inherited knowledge begins quietly to disappear; Sunaynā likewise observes the scarcity of old seeds. Two voices support the

perception of loss: a broadly surveying narrative voice and an individual informed by local experience. Neither establishes precisely how many varieties disappeared, over what territory or within what period. The grandmother's memory concerns one particular absence, not a full census of biodiversity. Critics must not announce complete biological extinction of all older seeds. The chapter gives loss a meaningful social reality while retaining important limits of scale and verification.

Seeds That "Know" Their Soil: Nonhuman Memory and Personification

The lyric says that an old seed recognizes its soil. The seed is thereby personified as though it remembers in a human fashion. The practical basis offered by the prose is familiarity with local growing conditions, particularly characteristic water regimes. Across the two levels, a relation between nature and culture is formed. Seeds do not become speaking characters, yet the actions taken to protect them make nonhuman life the object of narrative care. Environmental narration expands beyond the destruction caused by flooding to the preservation of future living possibility.

Achievement and Limits: A Combined Judgment

The episode's particular achievement is an image of coexistence: greater grain production and a commitment to keep surviving older seed alive. Sunaynā's modest jar and repeated seasonal planting are its most convincing actions. What remains undeveloped includes the social distribution of increased yields, effects of fertilizer, measured diversity, responsibility for the seed store and recovery of the particularly vanished variety. The song's generalized assurance of flood tolerance is broader than the one example supplied in prose. Once these distinctions are acknowledged, the narrative's construction of environmental memory retains substantial value without becoming unsupported technical advocacy.

Relations Across the Trilogy and Limits of the Source

Chapter [−51] draws on earlier famine and flood episodes, Ratnā's descendants, the channā grove and the land changes of [−54]. Its question resembles [−53]'s inquiry about electric light: when a new benefit arrives, how can useful older alternatives be preserved? The prior plan records 497 word units and 23.1 per cent action-indicating paragraphs for this chapter; neither figure should be presented as a fresh, independent count of real events. Primary evidence consists of the Sunaynā–Burhbā dialogue, her grandmother's rice recollection, cooperation with Ratnā's descendants and

the seed store. The following [–50] tests the preservation of memory under constraints upon public speech.

Two Domains of Planting: A Subtle Division of Narrative Space

In Sunaynā's field, the extensive planting of new seed and the small surviving plot of older rice coexist in the same physical geography. Rather than resolving the debate in a conference or doctrinal pronouncement, the novel gives it a material outcome along a field's edge. It does not discuss pollination between varieties or analyze biological consequences of their proximity. This is a narrated arrangement of planting, not a report of agricultural experimentation. The preservation of tradition becomes most credible within the story when translated into repeated seasonal labour.

A Variety Lost Beyond Narrative Recovery

One rice variety remembered by the grandmother is said to be absent from the entire village. Sunaynā subsequently preserves other older seeds, but the prose never says that this particular lost variety was rediscovered. The resolution therefore does not constitute complete recovery. It is an attempt to protect the remaining diversity. The difference between the lyric's confidence about saving the village and the limited success shown by the event deepens the episode's ethics. When something has already disappeared, the care given to what remains becomes more urgent.

Ownership of Traditional Seed and Community Access

Sunaynā and Ratnā's descendants help establish the store, but the text does not explain whether only their households may use its contents or whether other village cultivators have equal access. Its placement in a communal memorial grove does not automatically establish a distributive institution. Coming immediately after land reform, this omission is particularly significant: do newly landed farmers share in the protection of varietal diversity? Criticism may pose the question but must not invent either a distribution dispute or a fully egalitarian arrangement. The narrative is explicit about preservation, less so about its social governance.

Critical Section 51 | Original Chapter −50 — The Darkness of the Emergency

The Prehistory · A strictly narratological criticism based on the actual text of the original novel

The mechanical proportion indicated in the source is not an independent measure of actual event-density.

The Historical Date 1975: National Event, Local Shadow

Chapter [−50] explicitly invokes the national Emergency of 1975. A declaration made in Delhi reaches the Women's Night Assembly near the channā grove as surveillance and restrictions upon meetings. Rather than reconstructing the central machinery of national power, the narrator selects a local order: "No assembly without permission." The broad event of political history thus becomes a threat to one small institution. The year is specified, but not the exact date on which the order reached the village, the individual official who issued it, or a list of arrests. The text offers a village-bound memory of emergency restrictions rather than an administrative record. Within these limits it constructs an acute political tension.

An Assembly That Lit Lamps: A Change in the Visible Scene

Previously the women lit lamps by the channā grove to discuss justice. The new restriction endangers the assembly's public presence. Its organization is not simply destroyed; instead its sensory form changes. Lamps are extinguished, voices lowered, and finally whispers and glances carry conversation. This modification alters the visual grammar of the chapter. A communal court once visibly illuminated now continues in darkness through nearly imperceptible bodily signs. The survival of an institution is not the same as the preservation of its publicity. That difference forms the episode's principal conflict.

Sunaynā: From Preserving Seeds to Preserving the Assembly

Sunaynā protected older seed in [−51]; here she seeks Burhbā's advice on keeping the Night Assembly alive. The threatened object changes from biological diversity to a shared right to speak. The underlying pattern nevertheless continues: a valuable inherited institution must adjust its practices under pressure. Sunaynā openly fears the danger, but her fear does not render her inactive. The subsequent secret meetings make organization rather than mere exhortation the substance of her response. The character retains continuity without simply repeating the same task from the previous chapter.

"An Assembly for Justice, Not a Political Meeting": The Risks of Classification

Burhbā describes the women's gathering as an assembly of justice rather than a political meeting. This is a character's protective distinction, not proof that the law recognizes the gathering as exempt from restrictions. The boundary between discussing social justice and opposing forms of power is not inherently clear; the authorities already suspect the assembly. Burhbā's statement recalls its purpose and gives the women a moral basis for continuing cautiously. It must not be represented as an effective legal immunity conferred by the state. The simplified political classification also constitutes a limitation in the chapter's treatment of the Emergency.

Burhbā's Speech: A Warning Grounded in Long Memory

Burhbā's advice rests on the difficulty of restoring an institution once it has been allowed to die. He regards the period of darkness as temporary while recognizing that institutional destruction may outlast it. The two temporal scales allow his long memory to address an immediate risk. He does not predict the exact date on which the Emergency will end. The suggestion that rebuilding could take "an entire generation" is a possible, emphatic warning rather than a mechanically fixed restoration period. His essential lesson concerns continuity of collective practice, not a miraculous assurance of protection.

The Constable Passing Nearby: A Real Scene of Danger

The chapter's most concentrated scene occurs when a police constable passes close to the channā grove at night. The women hold their breath; only a slight sound from the pond remains audible. Very little happens externally—the constable approaches, notices nothing and moves on—yet the range of what could happen is frighteningly large. The narrative prolongs the felt duration of a moment. No arrest takes place. Tension is produced by the possibility of catastrophe that does not materialize. To add a raid, interrogation or detention would replace the story with events it never narrates.

A Held Breath: Political Darkness Within the Body

The proximity of the constable brings the women's physical movement and speech to a stop. Holding the breath carries the administrative restriction inside the body, turning political control from an abstract prohibition into a momentary constraint upon throat, lungs and gesture. The women remain invisible to the constable, while the reader draws close to their shared fear. This partial focalization is an effective artistic choice. Their separate thoughts, illnesses and family risks remain undescribed,

however. Bodily experience is presented as a collective sign rather than a series of fully individualized portraits.

The Slight Sound of the Pond: Making Silence Audible

When the women fall silent, the small sound of the pond survives. Nature does not take over their conversation or actively protect them; it gives the silence a perceptible acoustic background. Without that sound, the constable's approach might remain a bare announcement. The pond places the political scene inside the familiar sensory world of the novel's water-based memories. Neither the water nor its noise prevents the constable from seeing the women; its role is to shape atmosphere and attention. Distinguishing this sensory role from an invented physical or supernatural intervention is essential to a faithful reading.

The Assembly's Two Years: Duration and Summary

The narrative says that the women continue to meet secretly for two years. Every meeting is not separately dramatized. The description of arriving one by one and sitting in a circle gathers repeated actions into a general account. One tense episode involving the constable therefore sits beside a summary of long institutional persistence. The method accommodates years of political effect while maintaining brisk narrative movement. But it does not specify which cases were heard, which judgments were implemented or whether any member withdrew. Continuity is asserted and depicted in outline; detailed social outcomes of the assembly's work remain largely unseen.

Glances and Whispering: A Changed Medium of Discourse

After the lamps go out, the women carry their talk of justice by means of exchanged looks and whispers. Under pressure, ordinary public speech acquires forms that can scarcely be heard or seen. This is more than a stylistic change: the socially recognized setting of public testimony has contracted. Since the actual arguments and decisions are not quoted, the reader accepts the narrator's assurance that the work continues. The transformed form is a powerful figure for survival, while the everyday administration of justice is less clear. The aesthetic success of the scene and the evidentiary limits of its institutional claim must be distinguished.

No Paper, No Name Forgotten: The Limits of an Anti-Documentary Claim

The narrator declares that no documents were written during the clandestine period, yet no name was left out. Earlier episodes had made the shadow-register, manuscripts and print indispensable forms of record. Here secrecy interrupts written documentation and brings communal oral

memory into the foreground. The claim has considerable ethical resonance, but no individual register is supplied against which total retention can be checked. The earlier failure to record several flood victims' names makes its certainty especially significant. A responsible reading acknowledges the value of the community's refusal to forget while distinguishing that aspiration from verified completeness.

The Song's "Cannon in Delhi": Metaphor and Prose Limits

The song says that a cannon sounded in Delhi and newspapers fell silent. The prose describes the national Emergency, prohibition on assembly and police vigilance; it does not stage actual artillery fire in Delhi. The cannon can therefore be read as an audible figure for coercive power and fear. Turning it into a military bombardment would be an invented event. The silencing of newspapers is likewise a lyric indication; the prose does not portray the closing of a named village newspaper or an individual editor's story. The song produces a large image of collective repression while the prose concentrates on a small local scene.

The Channā Grove: A New Function as a Secret Stage

The grove had served as a public place for remembrance, shade, assemblies and varied communal action. Under the Emergency, it becomes the setting of concealed meetings. This changing use of recurring geography is a characteristic achievement of the long narrative: the same place alters its rules of visibility in response to history. Darkness shelters the women from outside observation, but also obliges them to suppress their own voices. Protection and restricted expression therefore arise together. The text gives no detailed map of vegetation, patrol routes or hiding places. Its spatial signs are sufficient for the scene's artistic purpose without constituting an operational geography.

Women's Polyphony: Collective Strength and Individual Absence

The assembly is composed of women, whose courage, fear and disciplined persistence are rendered as the actions of a collective. Sunaynā is its named organizer, but the other participants seldom acquire independent dialogue or identifiable disputes. The novel celebrates a women's institution while giving little space to its internal deliberations. Disagreement under political pressure would be plausible, but plausibility is not evidence of an episode; no such dispute should be manufactured. The necessary criticism concerns the narrator's selection: the power of collective characterization coexists with limited individualized focalization.

From the Dawn of Independence to Emergency Darkness

Chapter [−55] pictured independence as a new national dawn; Chapter [−50] shows state authority narrowing the public voice of a village assembly. This long-range contrast matters to the novel's historical architecture. Once secured, political freedom is not automatically depicted as guaranteeing uninterrupted freedom of speech. The public celebration beneath a tricolour and the women whispering in a dark grove invite comparison. Yet the later chapter does not trace an exhaustive constitutional history of the Emergency. It offers one locality's experience of restriction and thereby raises, rather than completely answers, larger political questions.

Reinterpreting Earlier Forms of Light

In [−53] the electrical bulb represented new development; in [−50] extinguishing a lamp becomes a practical condition of keeping a justice assembly alive. More light therefore need not mean more freedom. Conversation survives within the grove's darkness, while externally enforced publicity can invite surveillance. The reversal prevents "light" from becoming a fixed and exclusively positive symbol. Its ethical significance changes with setting, visibility and power. The episode shows how recurring imagery within the long novel can be reworked to produce new historical meaning instead of simply repeating earlier lessons.

The Final Lamp: A Limited Victory of Reappearance

After the Emergency ends, Sunaynā lights the lamp again and summons the assembly. The statement that its flame seemed to rise higher than before is introduced in the register of what "people say," giving it the touch of communal exaggeration. The height of the flame is an emotional sign of victory, not a measured phenomenon. The crucial change is that the assembly once more becomes public. The prose does not reveal in detail how clandestine decisions were subsequently enforced or whether every grievance was resolved. The victory concerns the reappearance of a collective voice, not the abolition of all injustice.

The Reader's Viewpoint: From Invisibility to Participation

The chapter first presents the official prohibition, then the experience of fear as a constable draws near, and finally the rekindled lamp. Administrative command, bodily alarm, persistent collective speech and relief form its four registers of perception. One night is dramatized at length while two years of activity are compressed. The selection is effective, though the reader values the Night Assembly's survival without hearing its actual cases. Criticism should assess this dependence upon narrative

assurance without denying the danger or the courage that the text does establish.

Overall Evaluation and Limits of the Source

The episode's most successful image is the held breath of the women as a constable passes while the pond makes its faint noise. Political control becomes bodily silence, and whispered discourse makes continued social organization possible. Limitations include the absence of detailed judgments during the secret meetings, sparse individual characterization of members, the challenge of remembering names without records, and the abbreviated account of official procedures. The source is Chapter [−50]; the plan records 466 word units and 23.1 per cent action-indicating paragraphs, not independent measurements of actual event-density. Chapter [−49] moves from this experience of political darkness to a year of drought and a different relation between state and community.

The Secret Meeting and the View of Power

The constable's gaze does not discover the women assembled at the grove, while the reader is allowed to share their fear and bodily silence. This unequal distribution of knowledge gives the reader more information than the representative of administrative power. The sentry seeks to see, yet fails to apprehend the community's actual meaning. The reader becomes a discreet witness to the women's hidden voices, and thus a participant in the narrative's ethical arrangement. Even here, however, readers do not learn the details of the assembly's decisions. Their privileged perspective and its limitations remain simultaneous.

Prose Time Under Government and Darkness Time in Song

The date 1975 fixes the particular historical horizon of the prose, while "darkness" in the lyric has a broader applicability to repeated forms of repression. The lyric therefore allows the episode to speak beyond its immediate period; the prose remains anchored to a particular emergency order's effects on one place. Read together, the levels preserve both historical specificity and cultural resonance. Reducing the darkness to the literal absence of light would erase its political meaning; treating the actual restrictions of 1975 as merely figurative would diminish the historical crisis. Both mistakes collapse distinct narrative functions.

The Scale of Resistance: Non-Events and Real Persistence

The constable arrests nobody, the assembly is not broken, and public illumination is temporarily suspended. The most consequential outcome is therefore something that does not happen: the institution's destruction is averted. This negative-event structure differs from an action story whose

resistance culminates in a spectacular victory. Sometimes keeping a practice alive is itself the significant act. The absence of an arrest in this particular scene does not establish that the Emergency was harmless or that no repression occurred elsewhere. The narrative claims persistence at one chosen village site, not an exhaustive historical judgment.

Critical Section 52 | Original Chapter −49 — The Year of Drought

The Prehistory · A strictly narratological criticism based on the actual text of the original novel

The mechanical proportion indicated in the source is not an independent measure of actual event-density.

A Rainless Sky: Disaster Reversed

In "The Year of Drought," the narrative is generated not by an excess of water but by its absence. Earlier flood episodes depicted water breaking its bounds; now the pond recedes until mud is exposed along its embankment and the ground begins to crack. Opposite states of the same watery environment deepen the ecological rhythm of the novel. The narrator speaks of an empty sky for months without giving a precise year or rainfall measurements. The earth's "thirst" is a physical condition rendered through personification, not evidence that the soil possesses human consciousness. The scarcity of water is an active narrative cause, rather than ornamental landscape.

Remembering Earlier Famines: Ratnā, Hulāsā and Sāvitrīdevī

The text recalls Hulāsā's hunger, famine in Ratnā's time and Sāvitrīdevī's long wait for relief. These retrospective indications prevent the current disaster from being merely an interchangeable recurrence. Readers can ask what the community has learnt to do differently. The earlier famines are not retold in full; their names act as mnemonic references across the long narrative. Here the significant new transitions are administrative cooperation, precise household accounting and renewed digging of an old well. A claim that "the village had endured famine before" is only the beginning of comparison, not its complete critical result.

Gopāl's Entry: Generational Responsibility and New Leadership

Sunaynā's son Gopāl appears as a young village headman. The passage to the next generation occurs in a sentence, while the function of leadership changes. Sunaynā guarded seed and maintained a secret assembly; Gopāl works with relief officials, records distribution and directs the reopening of a well. The difference shows succession as the acquisition of new institutional capacities, not mechanical repetition of ancestral duties. His education, method of selection and family disputes are not developed. Gopāl's character is defined by practical acts in a communal emergency rather than by a detailed private biography.

Government Assistance and Self-Help: An Altered Relationship

In [−62], the relief centre was distant and administrative formalities left hungry families waiting. In [−49], government assistance operates in time and Gopāl cooperates with officers in distributing grain. This is a consequential institutional alteration within the expansive story. State and community are not presented as natural and unchangeable enemies. Instead of repeating an earlier lesson against passivity, the novel narrates a new pattern of collaboration. It does not specify quantities, office names or exact delivery dates. "On time" is the narrator's general evaluation, not a numerical comparison of service intervals. The relation is nonetheless shown through bounded practical action.

"Who Has Been Left Out?": Accounting as the Narrative Centre

Gopāl records each household's need and grain allocation, paying attention to anyone omitted from relief or requiring more support. The community is not treated as a single crowd: each name becomes a possible claim upon food. In an earlier flood, names of several people from the Charmakār quarter were missing from records, giving the fear of omission a deep ethical history. No particular disputed entry is dramatized here; the story shows Gopāl's precaution rather than the resolution of an actual omission. Still, administrative counting becomes the moral centre of a life-preserving action: the record of names is intended to guide just allocation.

The Relief Store and the Well's Depth: Two Paths of Response

The community needs food and water, and the chapter pursues both. State grain distribution is an external resource for reducing hunger; reopening a disused well is a local source of water. The song condenses these complementary actions into the line "The state gives relief; the village gives accounts." That division should not be read too literally: in the prose both sides cooperate in material response and its organization. The episode joins assistance from beyond the village with labour drawn from within it, although the detailed history of the administrative and physical procedures is kept brief.

The Old Well: A Resource Sleeping in the Landscape

A well in the southern quarter has remained closed for years. Its reopening makes the site a carrier of both past neglect and present possibility. As the pond dries, the first glimpse of water in the well reveals another layer of the local water environment. The story does not say that every dry source is suddenly replenished or that this one well permanently satisfies the region. Its accomplishment is the discovery of water at one particular place through work. The southern location recalls the village's previously

vulnerable geography, but ownership of the well and any earlier pattern of exclusion are not specified. Such matters must remain open, not be filled in by assumption.

Hand to Hand, Soil Removed: The Scene of Collective Labour

Young people under Gopāl's direction dig, passing soil from hand to hand. As in the bucket chain during the fire and preparatory work against floodwater, cooperation acquires a recurring bodily rhythm. The objective, however, is different: rather than moving water outward, the workers descend toward it within the earth. "Sweat flowed all day" compresses the duration of effort without supplying depth, volume or tools. Exhausted bodies and the first sight of water become the emotional climax. The chapter portrays a communal act of digging, not a measured scientific survey of groundwater.

The First Glimpse of Water: A Decisive Event and Emotion

When water appears deep within the well, a visible reward finally answers collective effort. The narrator places "light" on the villagers' faces, repeating in emotional form an image associated with the earlier electric bulb. This illumination is not another actual lamp; it signifies relief in those who have laboured and thirsted. The difficult period is resolved narratively through a concentrated discovery, without an account of water supply for the remainder of the year. Nonetheless, the village changes its orientation: instead of only waiting for rain from the sky, it searches within its own ground for a source of life.

The Prose's "Old Hunger" and the Song's Enduring Name

The lyric says that a pond can dry but a name need not disappear. In prose, this commitment takes practical form through Gopāl's accounts and the preserved village copy. The memory of hunger becomes not simply a declaration of sympathy but an instrument of preparation for relief. The song's cycle of hunger coming and going does not amount to a guarantee that future famines are over. No subsequent year's rainfall, harvest or continued groundwater level is described. Poetic reassurance and narrated achievement therefore remain separate.

Gopāl's Notebook: The Reverse of Colonial Documentation

Thompson's notebook in [−57] rendered village customs through alienating classifications. Gopāl's notebook in [−49] seeks to register each household's actual needs. The material object of inscription is similar, but the authority, purpose and consequences differ. The visiting scholar created external categories; the local headman records data to make relief more equitable. The juxtaposition does not condemn or praise writing as such. It

asks who controls the record and for whose benefit. There is, however, no independent audit proving Gopāl's list error-free; the narrator emphasizes the beneficial purpose of his undertaking.

Office and Village: The Meaning of Two Copies

Gopāl files one account with the government office and retains another in the village collection. This duplicate record places writing under two kinds of custody. The administrative copy serves state relief procedures, while the village copy safeguards local memory and oversight. Unlike earlier anxieties about misrepresentation by an outsider, the two locations of the document are presented here as complementary rather than inherently hostile. The language, signatures, entries and methods of public inspection are not shown. The material and ethical importance of the duplicate is explicit; independent verification of its exact contents is impossible from the available prose.

The Long Inheritance of the Shadow-Register

Gopāl associates his notebook with the tradition of Yādavānand's shadow-register. A list compiled during a recent emergency therefore enters the village's longstanding lineage of communal writing. Names are no longer guarded only for the remembrance of the dead: the living household's claim to grain is also being recorded. The old register episode is not reproduced at length, but its invocation establishes an internal intertext. Written pages, songs and Burhbā's memory are not mutually exclusive; they perform distinct functions as circumstances change. Record-keeping may be protective when placed in accountable communal hands.

Burhbā's Satisfaction: A Character's Hope and Institutional Reality

Burhbā tells Gopāl that he once urged Sāvitrīdevī not to wait helplessly for relief, whereas now state and community work together. The contrast gives his memory a clear evaluative function: earlier insufficiency can be placed beside a particular improvement. It does not prove that all later governments have become universally effective or progressive. The episode describes beneficial cooperation in one drought. Burhbā's satisfaction is an emotion belonging to a character who has witnessed several generations, not a timeless certificate for the whole of administrative history. The distinction prevents an excessively celebratory interpretation.

Drought and Famine: Different Narrative Terms

At the opening, the prose depicts a failed monsoon, a shrinking pond and cracked land. It also suggests the danger of famine and describes a functioning relief system. The two conditions are related but not identical. Drought concerns scarcity of water; famine can involve access to food and

social distribution as well as weather. The narrator connects present relief with memories of previous hunger but offers no detailed grain prices, harvest losses or mortality statistics. One must therefore not introduce an unreported episode of mass starvation. Environmental beginnings, institutional action and evidenced outcomes require separate consideration.

The Limited Completeness of Name-Protection

Gopāl attempts to safeguard every name and every account, but the number of households and the actual entries are not reproduced. The desire that "no name be omitted" is a declared objective. It is not itself proof that the completed register includes everyone. The gap brings the novel's commitment to memory into contact with the practical difficulty of historical record-keeping. Criticism may regard the aspiration as a major strength while refusing to equate intention and independently demonstrated accuracy. The scene makes the ethics of an inclusive ledger visible without providing a full ledger for inspection.

Different Results in Recurring Disasters

The first famine's waiting, the bucket chain during the fire, flood evacuation, epidemic sanitation and the present well-digging are different kinds of collective response. When causes and actions change, repetition of "the village survived" becomes a developing pattern rather than simple recurrence. Chapter [−49] adds two relatively new elements: cooperation with state services and carefully retained written accounts. At the same time, repeated collective success risks idealization when private exhaustion, disagreement over allocations and failed attempts receive little scenic space. Both continuity of organizational learning and its limits belong in the evaluation.

Village Resources and Social Power

The well in the southern quarter is reopened collectively, but the text does not explain who lacked access to it before it was closed. Given the long history of unequal village resources, this omission is meaningful. Gopāl's household accounting expresses an inclusive intention, though no distribution table divided by caste or gender is reproduced. The narrator's satisfaction with apparently just distribution and a fine-grained inquiry into institutional power are different analytical levels. Where the text is silent, criticism should neither invent new discrimination nor certify perfect equality. It should identify the social question created by the narrative's chosen focus.

The Song's Well-Victory and Practical Uncertainty

"Where the pond was defeated, the well prevailed" turns water sources into antagonists in a vigorous lyric opposition. They are not literal combatants: a drying source is partly answered by the reuse of another. The prose shows the discovery of water, without guaranteeing its long-term cleanliness, replenishment or resistance to future drought. The song celebrates the immediate scene; it cannot serve as a lasting certificate of groundwater management. The personification has poetic energy precisely when kept separate from a claim of complete technical control over the environment.

The Final Achievement of the Drought Episode and the Next Medium

The chapter unites three acts: government grain distribution, local labour reopening a well, and a record preserved under community custody. Water and names are protected by different material means. Its limitations include the missing amounts of relief, grain and groundwater; sparse representations of power and families in need; and the absence of an inspectable register. The next [−48] introduces radio and television, changing the distribution of voices. The movement from a locally stored written copy to incoming sound and images establishes a clear connection between consecutive episodes about social communication.

Not a Crowd but Each Household: Data Within the Story

Gopāl pays attention to each household's requirements, allocated grain and possible omissions. This makes a name a practical unit for resource distribution rather than solely an object of cultural honour. The account of communal cooperation has a concrete rationale in this attempt at household-level accounting. But no genuine ration slip, named ledger entry or disputed allocation is quoted. The social importance of data is clear, while its numerical verification is unavailable. Precisely this distinction allows "accounting" to become a motive force in the narrative rather than a decorative bureaucratic detail.

The Awakening of a Closed Well: A Forgotten Resource

The well has stood closed for years, indicating that a resource once available within the community has fallen out of use. Gopāl's action is therefore not merely innovation but the recovery of a neglected capability. Memory becomes a search through the material geography of the village. Why the well was closed, who closed it and what earlier disputes surrounded access are not stated. It would be unwarranted to declare that it had been shut by a particular caste restriction or administrative order. The reopening is a narrated act; the complete history of closure remains incomplete.

Praise for Cooperation and the Unheard Voices of Officials

Officials assist Gopāl in distribution, but receive no names, dialogue or individual positions on policy. “The state” consequently appears as a useful institution rather than a fully independent group of characters. This choice keeps communal leadership at the centre. Assistance is said to be effective, though the chain of shipments and resource decisions is not described. To dismiss the administration or celebrate it as uniformly benevolent would both exceed the text. The demonstrable point is narrower: in this emergency, prompt government help and the community's own labour operate alongside one another.

Critical Section 53 | Original Chapter –48 — The Voices of Radio and Television

The Prehistory · A strictly narratological criticism based on the actual text of the original novel

The mechanical proportion indicated in the source is not an independent measure of actual event-density.

The First Voice from a Box at the Chaupal: A New Form of Distance

During Gopāl's time the first radio arrives at the village chaupal. A voice from Delhi heard through a small box brings sensory astonishment. Geographic distance is abruptly traversed by sound while the speaker's body and image remain elsewhere. People surround the radio, lean closer, close their eyes or listen intently: these distinct gestures form a compact scene of collective attention. The narrator calls it a "voice from Delhi," without naming the broadcaster or specifying the news. The opening event concerns the experience of a medium more than any identifiable content it transmits. The distinction is necessary to the artistic novelty of the scene.

A Leap of One Year: From Radio to Television

The prose says that the first television arrives "a year later." This brief passage of time takes the community from a medium of sound to a screen combining image and sound. The wavering black-and-white pictures provide a suitably imperfect sensory form for the novelty. No colour programmes, broadcasting centre or programme schedule are described. The first collective experience of the apparatus is the central event. The coming of television does not demonstrate that radio disappears. The narrator's compressed chronology presents technological change as a transition between epochs while leaving the uneven material distribution of devices largely unseen.

The Chaupal: From Collective Listening to Collective Viewing

The chaupal is the first public setting for both radio and television. Technology thereby enters the narrative as an apparently shared occasion rather than a private household purchase. People gather around the devices and watch together on recurring evenings. The assembly place becomes a centre of news, entertainment and coordinated attention. Yet the text does not say which families can buy private receivers or who has difficulty accessing the public screen. The phrase "the whole village" creates a collective impression, not documentary proof that every individual is present. The narrative depicts a memorable public experience instead of a complete register of social access.

Fewer Listeners Beneath the Peepal: A Threat to the Older Story

Children who once gathered to hear Burhbā now sit before the television. This is a directly narrated indication of competition between media. Habits of attention, time and place change; the memory tradition is not shown as destroyed, but its immediate audience grows smaller. The number of children, the programmes they watch and the days on which they stop coming to the peepal are not stated. "The children" are a generalized group undergoing a shift. The threat lies in actual changed listening behaviour, not in evidence for an inevitable total disappearance of village culture.

Women's Song on the Embankment: An Unequal Field of Sound

The songs of women on the village embankment are drowned out by the louder sound of the new devices. The contrast is more than old folk music against new entertainment: it concerns control over audible public space. Mechanically amplified sound can occupy territory that a collective human voice cannot. But the prose does not show who operates the volume controls or whether the women protest or seek another place to sing. The effect is narrated, while the social contest behind it is not fully staged. Criticism can examine the distribution of acoustic power without inventing an actual quarrel over a loudspeaker.

Kusum, Gopāl's Daughter: A New Generation's Question

Kusum asks Burhbā whether his work will become easier now that the whole world appears able to enter the village. The question expresses a straightforward optimism about technology; Burhbā's answer identifies a possible reverse effect upon local attention. Female succession continues through a distinct new problem. Sunaynā had considered saving seeds; Kusum notices the changing habits of young listeners. She does not stop at asking for advice. At the chapter's close she begins telling stories in the new circumstances. Her movement from question to action gives her an active role within the long narrative of custodianship.

"Voices from Outside" and "Songs from Within": A Simple Opposition

Burhbā distinguishes incoming voices that fill the ear from songs arising within the community that fill the heart. Direction of origin becomes a metaphor for difference in value. The prose, however, does not prove that outside news is always mere noise or that every internal story is true. Later, news of a distant flood prompts elders to remember their own experience, showing that an outside voice can revive local knowledge. The narrated exception complicates the aphorism's polarity and prevents an entirely

prohibitive reading of new media. The contrast is suggestive, but not an exhaustive social law.

One News Image: A Distant Flood and Nearby Memory

Television shows news of a flood in a distant country. Watching the submerged homes, elders fall silent as their own previous floods return to mind. This is a significant narrated bridge between mediated external events and village remembrance. The very device that diverted children from listening to Burhbā can awaken the community's memories of water and loss. The episode therefore qualifies the character's general warning within the events of the story itself. The distant country's name, the date of the report and death toll are not supplied. The point is the unexpected recurrence of memory, not a complete record of international news.

The Silent Elders: An Unvoiced Level of Experience

After the televised flood, "the old people fell silent." Their quiet indicates shared generational experience, but the text does not specify which past inundations each had witnessed or which homes they had lost. Silence carries moral weight without granting every viewer an independent psychology. Eyes are fixed on the screen while thought returns to an earlier watery landscape: two places coincide in one moment. Earlier flood episodes give this response an internal intertextual foundation. News is not merely new information; it becomes the occasion for reopening an older narrative within the listener.

The Television Screen: An Enlargement of Narrative Space

Earlier floods occurred along the Kamalā-Balān, in the Charmakār quarter, near the old cremation ground or beneath the peepal. Now an unnamed river far away enters the chaupal through a screen. The village stays in place while its field of vision extends outward. The screen compresses distant geography into a domestic or communal object, granting the impression of proximity. But the levels of action remain separate: villagers watch a report, whereas the flood depicted in that report does not physically occur in the novel's village. Confusing mediated and immediate events would inflate the narrative's actual event count.

Kusum's Response: Change the Stage, Do Not Switch Off the Device

Kusum does not turn off the television. She begins to tell the older stories again to the children assembled in its orbit, turning the new apparatus or gathering into a "new stage." Resistance thus takes the form of appropriation and reorganization, not suppression. It is an active attempt to regain listeners rather than merely restate that names must survive noise. Yet the text does not say her stories are broadcast on television. "New

stage" principally denotes a changed local storytelling setting or an experimental possibility, not a fully established transmission service. Keeping that boundary intact preserves both the ingenuity of the character and the uncertainty of the form.

How the New Medium Allocates Time

Children gather for evening television sessions, occupying time once spent listening near the peepal. The decisive contest concerns available hours and attention, not the physical destruction of older objects. Kusum's response is described as storytelling every evening, another iterative account that gathers repeated practice into one sentence. A new routine emerges, but whether every household participates is not specified. The recurrent audience suggests the possibility of continued transmission, not a comprehensive attendance register or a guarantee about all subsequent generations.

Radio and the Earlier War Reports in Chapter [−52]

Chapter [−52] had already described wartime news heard on a radio, while [−48] now tells of the "first radio" arriving in the village. This creates a real chronological problem. It might be possible that the earlier reports came from a market or an outside receiver and that the present episode concerns the first radio owned or installed at the chaupal. But the source does not establish that distinction. The discrepancy should therefore be recorded as an unresolved media chronology or narrative inconsistency, not silently repaired through an invented explanation. It is a small but consequential point in the long novel's historical ordering.

Electricity in [−53] and Television in [−48]

The electric bulb of [−53] had drawn attention together through communal astonishment; the screen's light now draws children away from oral storytelling. The work of technical illumination changes from a shared spectacle to the commanding attraction of an outside visual world. Yet Harivansh's annual remembrance beneath the bulb and Kusum's evening stories provide analogous responses: bring inherited memory into conversation with the new medium. Such recurrence maintains the long narrative's central concern, though repeated solutions can risk appearing schematic. The new elements here are the redistribution of listener time and the capacity of external news to prompt old memories.

The Book in [−57] and the Screen in [−48]

Thompson's book had misclassified the village's customs; radio and television import selected outside voices and images. Both episodes raise questions about who controls mediated narration. They are not, however,

identical cases of distortion. The television chapter does not show a programme falsely describing village tradition. Its concern is the medium's command over attention and the shrinking time devoted to local storytelling. The earlier book involved direct textual misrepresentation; the screen involves altered listening patterns. Conflating the two would impose a charge on the later medium that the prose never substantiates.

Women on the Embankment and Children Before the Screen: Whose Audience?

Women singing on the embankment and children watching television at the chaupal form distinct communities of sound within one village. The stronger reach of an apparatus suppresses the audible presence of women, while younger people's listening habits change. Gender and generation therefore meet, though the prose does not establish a scene in which men exclusively operate the television or women are formally prohibited from attending. The critic may examine the suggested imbalance without replacing textual evidence with a conjectured act of exclusion. Kusum tries to restore child listeners; the text does not report that the women's songs become fully audible again.

The Actual Discursive Difference Between “Noise” and “Song”

The folk song labels outside voices noise and inward songs the sounds worth protecting. Prose renders radio as a whispering box, television as a trembling image and women's song as a comparatively quiet voice. Outside sound is not always the loudest in a literal acoustical sense. The media descriptions are symbolic rather than measured decibel readings. The new apparatus can command attention because of curiosity and social organization, not just mechanical volume. This nuance prevents the critical issue of power from collapsing into a simple numerical difference in loudness.

Burhbā's Changing Role: Witness and Thinker About Media

Earlier, Burhbā remembered places and names during floods, fires and famines. Now he worries about the survival of the village's own voice amid incoming sounds. The threat is less the destruction of a body than displacement of attention and weakening of communication across generations. He does not order the devices smashed or banned. Instead he poses a tension to which Kusum responds by making a place for stories in the new situation. His warning finds its practical answer in renewed storytelling, not in the absolute refusal of technology.

The Aesthetics of a "New Stage" for Folk Narrative

Kusum's use of the "new stage" is a self-conscious sign of literary form. The novel repeatedly examines the passage among song, folklore, registers, dramatic staging and modern media; here the desire to transform narrative forms becomes a character's action. The precise form of the stage is not defined: it might indicate a communal storytelling session after television viewing rather than a produced broadcast. The phrase must therefore remain an open possibility, not be turned into a specified television programme. Its very openness gives Kusum creative agency while delimiting what can be claimed from the source.

Evaluation: Two Paths of Criticism and Adaptation

The chapter recognizes both the new medium's strong attraction and the marginalization of local songs. At the same time, distant flood news awakens memory, giving technology a constructive role as well. Kusum's response joins the two tendencies: neither the destruction of the device nor surrender of the tradition, but a reconfigured public occasion for storytelling. The limitations are unsupplied programme details, sound operators, the fate of women's songs, the distribution of audiences, and especially the chronology of radio between [−52] and [−48]. Its achievement is an examination of how the places and times of listening are reorganized socially.

Source, Intertexts and the Following Sequence

Primary evidence is original Chapter [−48]: the arrival of radio, collective television viewing, the Kusum–Burhbā dialogue, the distant flood report and the reorganized storytelling. Comparing Thompson's outside book in [−57], electrification in [−53] and wartime radio reports in [−52] reveals different forms of media authority. The next [−47], "The Gulf Market," turns to migration, earnings and memories of home. This chapter traces the movement of voices across distance; the next follows the movement of human bodies abroad.

The Truth of Television News and the Narrator's Restraint

A distant flood report recalls the village's past disasters to elderly viewers. The text does not tell us how the report was edited or whose viewpoint its broadcaster adopted. It therefore does not establish that mediated news must inevitably misrepresent events; outside images can become a stimulus to remembrance. By contrast, Thompson's publication had demonstrably attached dismissive terms to village practices within the novel. The two cases carry different evidentiary weights. Rather than a complete treatise on media literacy, the chapter supplies one troubling and one constructive social effect. The critical translation must preserve that duality.

A Divided Audience and a Possible Reunion

Traditional listeners near the peepal, television viewers at the chaupal and women singing along the embankment form three centres of attention. In actual village life their memberships might overlap, but the narrative distinguishes them by their different uses of time and sound. Kusum's storytelling begins to close the gap between the first two. The story does not say that the women's singing community has regained equal acoustical space. The ending is therefore the beginning of an audience's return, not proof of complete cultural unity. This limited resolution makes the proposed adaptation more credible.

Modern Media and the Self-Conscious Future of Storytelling

The dispute over radio, television and folk narrative invites the reader to think about the novel's own narrative form. A written book is itself preserving a village's oral voices; Kusum likewise carries inherited stories into an age of technical devices. The chapter, however, narrates neither the author's real publishing history nor a particular future digital edition. Those are interpretative possibilities, not demonstrated fictional events. At the literary level, the lasting contribution is to make the problem of how stories are conveyed part of the story being told.

Critical Section 54 | Original Chapter −47 — The Gulf Market

A New Geography of Migration and an Old Narrative Question

The Gulf migration of the 1980s opens a new economic direction in the communal history of Garh Narikel. Young men leave for construction work in Dubai, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia; agents, passports and visas become subjects of conversation in the marketplace. The narrator relates this movement to, while distinguishing it from, Yashpati's earlier indentured migration. The point is not that the two experiences are historically identical. Rather, departure, bodily labour and the remembrance of names return as narrative questions under altered conditions. Repetition carries change within it. The older story is neither simply reenacted nor rendered irrelevant by the new labour market.

Opening Proverb: Money and Names as Two Distinct Values

"The foreign market gives money; the hearth at home gives a name": the opening saying separates two spheres of value. The first concerns the sale of labour and the remittance of wages; the second concerns intimacy, household remembrance and continuing relationships. Yet the proverb goes further, warning that a person who forgets his name abroad may return a stranger in his own village. The principal prose does not narrate Ramesh forgetting his language or returning as an alienated stranger. Indeed, he regularly sends letters and money. To turn the proverb's warning into his actual fate would violate the evidentiary limits of the narrative.

Narrative Time: A Decade, Three Years and an Unnarrated Return

The episode begins in the broad time of the "eighties," whereas Ramesh's individual situation is marked by a three-year contract. These are two distinct temporal scales: the recurring departures of many families and the specified term of one worker. The chapter does not depict Ramesh returning on a particular date at the completion of that term. Its closing memorial is instead created in hope of his safe homecoming. Consequently, this story ends within an incompletely resolved period of waiting, not with the ceremonial finality of a return. The contractual duration must not be mistaken for a narrated outcome.

From Collective Migration to Ramesh's Individual Example

"Every few months," another young man leaves carrying a tin trunk. This is iterative narration: multiple departures are compressed into a recognisable scene-type. Within the pattern, the journey of Ramesh,

Kusum's husband, to Dubai becomes an individual example. The narrative moves from migration as a social phenomenon to remittances and changes in the market, then to the emotional absence felt within a household. Thus the reader encounters more than an abstract account of international employment. At the same time, the compression prevents the varied trajectories of other migrants from developing as separate personal histories.

The Tin Trunk: A Concrete Object Carried by a Departing Body

The young men depart with "tin trunks." That small object gives economic migration a bodily, visible form: the employment journey begins at the threshold of the home. The text does not enumerate its contents, identify who packed it or describe a complete farewell ceremony. Critical writing must not fill that silence with invented incidents. Yet the trunk remains effective. It converts a large and otherwise impersonal movement of people into a compact, readable image of departure and a point at which the village's familiar space meets a much wider geography of labour.

Ramesh's Letters, Money and Telephone Calls: Three Forms of Communication

Ramesh regularly sends letters and money; occasionally his voice reaches Kusum through the telephone line. A letter has the duration of delivery, a remittance carries material assistance, and a call permits brief auditory proximity across distance. The narrative contrasts these possibilities with the age of Ramsevak. However, it quotes neither Ramesh's letters nor a full telephone conversation and specifies no amount remitted. More efficient communication does not make the migrant a fully represented speaking character. We hear of his voice through the narrator rather than receiving his words directly. Technical proximity and narrative absence therefore coexist.

Kusum's Focalization: Economic Improvement and the Experience of Absence

Kusum forms the emotional centre of the migration episode. Ramesh's empty place becomes especially noticeable during festivals, weddings and songs associated with marriage. The narrator reports her feeling without developing an extended interior monologue; several seasons of waiting are compressed into a phrase. Money arriving at home signals economic alteration, but material improvement and the cost of conjugal separation are distinct outcomes. Kusum is not simply a conventional image of a wife who waits. She eventually makes a decision of her own and establishes a

sign of remembrance, thereby intervening in the village's shared symbolic arrangements.

A Concrete Roof and an Empty Courtyard: A Spatial Counterpoint

Several houses gain solid roofs; weddings become more affordable and new goods arrive in the marketplace. The narrator immediately sets these visible improvements against the image of an empty courtyard. The outer structure of the house appears more secure while the life of domestic presence is diminished. This spatial opposition gives migration its double value. Yet the text offers no household-by-household remittance account, nor does it show that every family benefited equally. Quantifiers such as "several" must be retained. The narrative juxtaposes economic opportunity and emotional absence; it does not establish a complete distributive survey of the gains of migration.

Economic Causation and the Absence of the Workplace

The overseas oil boom, construction work and contractual employment provide the announced causal background. Dubai itself is not rendered as a detailed workplace. Wages, work hours, accommodation, danger, recruitment fees and legal protection receive no independent narrative treatment. Overseas labour enters principally through the village's perspective. That selection is intelligible in a novel whose central concern is communal remembrance in Garh Narikel, but it is also a limitation of a chapter titled after a market. The labourer's own experience is substantially abbreviated, even though the consequences of his distant work are visible at home.

Ramsevak and Ramesh: An Intergenerational Comparison

Burhbā distinguishes Ramesh's circumstances from those of Ramsevak. Their stories are connected by geographical distance and the problem of maintaining relationships, but communication conditions have changed. Ramesh is neither Ramsevak reborn nor a worker subject to exactly the same migration regime. Letters, money orders and telephone calls alter what contact can mean. Through the comparison, the novel tests an old problem under new technical conditions without reducing history to literal repetition. The changing instruments of contact form one of the clearest differences between the two episodes.

Burhbā's Voice: Ethical Limits and Narrative Authority

Burhbā does not condemn earning money abroad. His concern is that, in pursuing money, one might lose the language, village and names through which relationships are sustained. The dialogue gives him interpretative authority. Ramesh is absent and cannot offer an alternative view of

Burhbā's warning. Kusum asks questions and eventually acts independently, but much of the evaluative conclusion comes through the long-lived witness's speech. This concentration of moral explanation is both a recurrent formal device and a limitation within a supposedly many-voiced social world.

Can a Name Be Left in the Market? Delimiting the Metaphor

The assertion that overseas labour places the body in a market compresses the human implications of selling work. Burhbā extends it into the possibility that a name too might be left behind. The text does not, however, depict Ramesh undergoing linguistic amnesia or making a return stripped of values. To convert figurative caution into an accusation would attribute an unsupported failure to the character. A more exact reading recognises the conditional claim: identity is maintained through repeated relationships and practices, while the question of whether remittances alone can preserve these ties remains open.

The Song's Voice and the Prose Ending: Divergent Destinies

The song "The Road to the Gulf" imagines the possibility of a migrant who comes home as a stranger. The prose ends without depicting Ramesh's return. It shows Kusum establishing a sign of hope. A caution that sounds almost conclusive in the song therefore differs from the suspended expectation of a particular family in the prose. The song offers a communal formula; the narrative preserves an unresolved present. Keeping those levels distinct allows opportunity, suffering and hope to remain simultaneously active within a chapter whose title foregrounds the market.

A New Marker Near Ramsevak's Old Marker at Jorī Pond

Kusum places a new marker for Ramesh near Ramsevak's older memorial by the roots beside Jorī Pond. The narrator explicitly says that this is not a marker of death but one of hope for a safe return. The familiar place changes its function: a site associated with death or disappearance becomes a communal sign for an absent person who is expected back. Past loss and future possibility occupy the same physical ground. The marker's material, inscription and exact form are not described; its principal meaning lies in the purpose the prose declares.

The "Lamp of Waiting": Time Made Visible

Kusum hopes that the sign will become a "lamp of waiting" for future sons who travel abroad. No literal lighting of a lamp is narrated here; the illumination belongs to the metaphor. The marker reserves a social place for a person's possible future return, rather than simply cataloguing a completed death. Through a single physical gesture, personal waiting

becomes the possible foundation of a recurring communal custom. The language of light renders delayed reunion visible without certifying either a homecoming or the complete establishment of a new institution.

Women's Action and the Gendered Division of Labour

Migrants appear mainly as young men, while Kusum remains within the worlds of the household, celebration and waiting. The distribution constructs a contrast between male economic mobility and female local responsibility for memory. Yet Kusum's final action prevents her from being a wholly passive figure: she changes the meaning of a public place. What the prose does not develop is her own livelihood, the organisation of domestic labour or the economic autonomy of her decisions. Criticism may identify that absence without supplying an imagined record of work the text itself does not give.

Few External Events, a Long Emotional Duration

The main narrated actions are departure, remittances, intermittent communication, material improvement and the placing of a marker. Their emotional duration reaches across years of festivals and waiting. This disparity between relatively few external incidents and extended felt time distinguishes the episode. Burhbā's interpretative discourse slows the movement before Kusum's action supplies a concrete closing image. A mechanical count of verbs would therefore give an inadequate measure of its narrative density, for the chapter's temporal force arises largely from recurring absence.

Connection to Chapter [−48]: A Reply After Broadcasting

In Chapter [−48], radio and television carry external voices into the village; here, letters, money and telephone calls sustain relationships with a person overseas. “Communication” names both processes, but their narrative work is different. The earlier problem concerns the dominance of external sound over local storytelling. The present one concerns auditory proximity to an absent family member. Taken together, the chapters reject any simple claim that technology inevitably destroys or inevitably liberates communal memory. Meaning depends on use and on the particular form of distance involved.

Ownership of the Name: Village and Diaspora

Burhbā maintains that Ramesh has kept his name in the village. “Name” here signifies more than identification on a document: it is the persistence of participation in a language, festivals and family ties even when the body is elsewhere. The difficulty is that the narrative does not show the world Ramesh creates for himself in Dubai. Roots are defined almost entirely

from the stable perspective of the village, while the migrant's possible multiple localities and evolving identities receive little space. The argument for remembrance is powerful, but the account of a migrant's independent self-understanding remains incomplete.

Conclusion: Opportunity and Separation Without Final Resolution

The chapter refuses to turn migration into either nothing but wealth or nothing but pain. Solid roofs coexist with empty courtyards, and a new sign reserves a place for living hope. Its limitations are equally clear: Ramesh lacks an independent voice; overseas work is unseen; the actual outcome of return is not supplied. Within that incompleteness, Kusum's definite action carries the episode beyond Burhbā's moral argument. The old narrative of separation expands into the Gulf-market era without being granted a manufactured solution.

Textual Basis and the Question That Follows

This reading rests on the song "The Road to the Gulf," the account of employment in the 1980s, Ramesh and Kusum's circumstances, Burhbā's dialogue, and the new marker beside Ramsevak's sign. Later chapters may further test changes in relationships, technologies and the identities of younger generations. Events not supplied by this particular chapter cannot be treated as already established merely because they would be plausible within such a history.

Critical Section 55 | Original Chapter −46 — The Test of Communal Harmony

From External Rumour to Communal Crisis: The Opening Situation

Toward the end of the 1980s, tension between religious communities in neighbouring areas reaches Garh Narikel in the form of rumours. A few visitors from outside try to sow distrust between Hindus and Muslims, and the atmosphere at the chaupal grows uneasy for a night or two. This establishes the possibility of rupture, not an already completed episode of extensive violence. The distinction matters: the folk song employs imagery of a fire being kindled, but the principal prose narrates neither a house being burned nor an actual riot in this episode. The heat of a metaphor is not evidence for an incident the text has not described.

The Song "The Shared Peepal": An Ethical Assurance Before the Crisis

The song begins by affirming a common pond, shared soil and shared grain. Thus, before the reader encounters the conflict in prose, a cultural answer to it has already been offered. The song makes a common memory readily available as a response to rumour, but it also diminishes dramatic uncertainty by anticipating reconciliation. Its communal voice is harmonious from the beginning, whereas the prose admits a short period of real doubt and tension. The song's placement places a reassuring frame around what might otherwise be a more unstable social confrontation.

The Event Sequence: Arrival, Tension, Response and Public Restoration

The narrative's minimum sequence has four turns: outsiders arrive; rumours spread distrust; a maulvi and a pandit recall the village's shared past; and a gathering for harmony takes place beneath the peepal. Joint participation in festivals is then announced as a renewed practice. Harmony is therefore not simply an untested background condition. The perceived threat compels the community to express it publicly. Yet the actual content of the rumours, the persons most affected and the depth of the tension receive few independent scenes. The movement from division to restoration is swift and highly selective.

Muslim Families: Presence Versus Independent Narrative Voice

The prose specifically acknowledges generations of Muslim families sharing labour, floodwater and village life with other inhabitants. Their presence in the fictional community is not in doubt. The difficulty

concerns the degree of independent voice made available to them. No particular Muslim woman, farmer or young person is given a developed personal dialogue. An "old maulvi," identified by office rather than personal name, joins a pandit in invoking shared memory. The relevant critical question is thus not whether Muslims are present, but whose individual experience is compressed when communal harmony is represented through a collective image.

The Maulvi and the Pandit Enter Together: Visual Symmetry

The two religious representatives stand together at the chaupal, making a visual equivalence before their words are heard. They recall who rescued whom during floods and whose food once kept another family's hearth alight. Earlier environmental catastrophes thereby cease to be mere backstory and become arguments in a present social crisis. The exact names of the rescued persons and the dates of those flood episodes are not quoted in this chapter. It is legitimate to recognise a shared history within the novel, but not to manufacture more specific events in order to make that memory appear documentary.

"Water from the Same Pond": A Communal Argument Drawn from Geography

Jorī Pond has repeatedly figured as a site of life, catastrophe and memory. Here its shared water becomes an image through which religious separation can be challenged. The pond is not the exclusive possession of one community in the chapter's moral vocabulary; it is a place of overlapping experience. Yet the shared use of water does not, by itself, prove that rights to every social resource were equally distributed. The narrative establishes a particular history of interdependence. Both its beauty as a place-based argument and the incompleteness of its account of social equality need to be acknowledged.

Kusum's Question: A Public Rumour Enters a Personal Dialogue

Kusum tells Burhbā that people from outside are trying to divide the village. Through her familiar voice, a diffuse danger acquires a more immediate form. She does not specify an act of violence or accuse named members of a community. Burhbā responds by recalling the common traditions, names and events that constitute local history. The chapter does not clearly narrate Kusum beginning a separate campaign of her own to unite the communities; the subsequent meeting is described collectively. Her narrative role here is primarily to carry the crisis into the familiar setting of consultation.

“Division Comes from Outside”: The Narrator's Simplified Causal Line

Burhbā's insistence that division comes from outside rather than from within expresses the work's ideal of solidarity. Yet the prose itself admits that uncertainty spreads in the village for a night or two. External rumours are able to produce internal questions. The narrative does not investigate possible links between communal suspicion and the village's existing differences of caste, property, authority or social memory. This creates a somewhat one-directional explanation of the crisis. The claim of internal harmony should be read as an ideal advanced within the fictional world, not as an unrestricted sociological law.

Rumour as an Unseen Power of Narrative

Rumour acts upon people, but the words of any particular rumour are not directly reproduced. Nor are the visitors named or their methods of persuasion developed. This choice avoids repeating hateful claims and holds the focus on the communal response. At the same time, the antagonistic speakers remain nearly inaudible, and the reader cannot assess their specific means of influence. The story establishes the possibility of harm without dramatizing its mechanism fully. As a result, the community's restoration of confidence occurs with relatively little represented debate.

Shared Memory as a Narrative Counterargument

The maulvi and pandit recall a common history; Burhbā reinforces the importance of safeguarding names. Mutual assistance during earlier floods, famines and disasters is brought forward as a response to present distrust. Memory is no longer merely an archive but a resource for social argument. The novel's earlier episodes supply context for these references, although the present discussion does not reproduce a verbatim debate or testimony from everyone involved. The past is activated through selective recollection. Its rhetorical power depends on the reader's sense of a longer common history, not on documentary completeness within this one scene.

The Fire in Chapter [−60] and the “Fire” in This Song

In “The Night of Fire,” houses actually burned; villagers passed water in a human chain, and the grove was endangered. In the song belonging to the present chapter, a “fire” to be extinguished represents social division. No fresh conflagration is described in the prose. The return of the same word therefore constitutes a transformation, not a literal recurrence. Physical fire and figurative social heat operate at separate levels. An analysis based only on repeated imagery would miss the distinction between an environmental disaster and a threatened breakdown of relationships.

From a Meeting to a Recurring Custom

Hindu and Muslim villagers gather beneath the peepal, light lamps and inquire after one another. Joint participation in the occasions of Eid and Diwali is then represented as an ongoing practice. A single crisis has thus given rise to the narrated establishment of a communal custom, a familiar structural movement within this long novel. Yet no year-by-year depiction of those meetings or complete list of participants follows. The expression "from that night onward" compresses subsequent recurrence into a narrator's summary. The existence of a custom is announced, not individually demonstrated at every later festival.

The Peepal's Shared Shade: A Place Reassigned a Social Function

The peepal has served as the centre of remembrance, Burhbā's presence and many village rituals. In this chapter its shade becomes a public place for coexistence rather than a gathering confined to a particular religion. The movement from a tense chaupal to the common seating beneath the tree gives reconciliation a spatial form. Nevertheless, physical proximity does not automatically establish equality in the opportunity to speak. The text does not specify the distribution of seats or the time given to individual representatives. A shared place is an effective symbol, but the conditions of equal participation remain only partly developed.

The Folk Song's "We" and the Social Plural

The song uses a collective "we" to weave different communities into a single speaking voice. Such a plural can draw listeners into an experience of solidarity. It can also reduce the distinctiveness of different practices, histories and grievances. In particular, Muslim families are not given an extensive independent religious or cultural utterance. The plural pronoun thus functions simultaneously as an inclusive sign and, at moments, as a substitute for individual speech. These possibilities coexist within the poetic construction of the community.

Religious Representatives and the Collective Protagonist

Although the maulvi and pandit jointly recall the past, the chapter does not stop with the authority of these representatives. Its final gathering belongs to the community. The two figures interpret the shared history, while villagers enact public reconciliation. The distribution of narrative roles matters; it prevents the whole achievement from being credited to an individual mediator. Yet named families and precise contributions remain scarce. To produce a concise emblem of harmony, the text abbreviates the complexities of individual social experience.

Chronological Uncertainty and the Limits of Historical Attribution

"The late eighties" provides the broad chronological setting. The chapter names no particular date, riot in another city, political organisation or identifiable national event as the precise source of the rumours. It would be unsound to impose specific historical incidents, casualties or speeches upon this fictional account. The work uses a recognisable atmosphere of modern history, but the narrated local crisis is compressed and not documented as a historical case study. Literary chronology and external historical records must be distinguished.

A Didactic Ending and a Still-Open Communal Question

The narrator closes by declaring that Garh Narikel has passed its test of communal harmony. The common meeting and the recollection of mutual aid ground that moral judgement. However, the chapter does not establish that hostile visitors never returned, that prejudice disappeared permanently or that later generations faced no new tensions. The affirming conclusion belongs to this particular episode. Within a longer novel, the possibility of further challenges remains open, even when the immediate test has been resolved.

Evaluation: A Story of Harmony and Its Simplifications

The chapter's achievement lies in activating shared water, the memory of former disasters and the paired appearance of maulvi and pandit against a current of suspicion. Its limits are the faintness of the opposing voices, the lack of Muslim individual perspectives and the over-simple account of division as entirely external. The song's fire is not a prose riot. Accordingly, the passage is neither a complete history of communal violence nor a meaningless moral lecture. It is a brief, idealised scene of crisis resolution through communal remembrance.

Source Limits and the Next Question

The primary material is the song "The Shared Peepal," the late-1980s episode of rumour, the joint remembrance conducted by maulvi and pandit, Kusum's dialogue with Burhbā and the renewed custom of shared festivals. These elements establish Muslim families as participants in the village's fictional history. They do not supply named victims of violence, another actual fire or a detailed interreligious debate. In the next chapter, the meaning of the "outside" changes: the force arriving from elsewhere becomes an economic attraction rather than a political threat.

Critical Section 56 | Original Chapter −45 — The Winds of Liberalisation

1991: The Importance of an Explicit Year

The chapter opens by naming the economic reforms of 1991. Unlike the loosely dated unrest at the end of the preceding decade, the national historical reference is precise. The story does not dramatise the drafting of a policy, the passage of a law or the presentation of a budget. Its interest is in the local manifestations of economic change: new commodities, cable television, private employment and growing desires for consumption. A process associated with national and global economics enters village life through objects and the changing pace of family relationships. The historical marker is explicit, but its institutional complexity is substantially compressed.

The "Wind" of the Title: A Figure of Mobile Change

"Winds of Liberalisation" gives the transformation an invisible, extensive and mobile character. Doors open, leaves stir and roots must be protected in the accompanying song. The imagery makes the market's coming less a single violent invasion than a widespread alteration of everyday conditions. "Roots" stand for communal memory, language and identity. The metaphor holds continuity and movement within one figure, but the prose shows that familiar evening gatherings do change. Roots are therefore not self-sustaining facts; they are maintained through social practice. The image is a cultural argument, not a guarantee that every tradition will survive.

The Inventory of Goods: Consumer Change Made Visible

Colourful plastics, smooth fabrics and numerous cable-television channels create a sensory inventory of the new economic situation. The catalogue renders a general change in policy visible through the colour, polish and proliferation of objects. It does not report prices, patterns of ownership, conditions of production or the people excluded from consumption. Novelty is unmistakable, equal distribution is not. The list creates a fast opening impression of the market's arrival while leaving many of the inequalities through which markets operate outside the frame.

Dinesh's Employment: An Abbreviated Story of Personal Advancement

Kusum's son Dinesh obtains a job in a private company. The narrator calls this an opportunity that had previously been impossible, a judgement that

must be understood within the story's own account of this family's circumstances, not converted into the claim that India had no private employment before 1991. Dinesh's position, salary, work conditions and office are not narrated. A national transformation is rapidly connected to one family's life through an employment outcome, not through a fully developed personal struggle. The brevity makes advancement legible while leaving its experience largely unexplored.

"Wanting More, Running Faster": A Change in Experienced Time

New desires arising from the marketplace alter the village's use of time even more clearly than its supply of objects. Earlier the community assembled near the peepal for "slow, steady evenings"; now those gatherings grow thin. Economic speed becomes a theme of narrative temporality. The market accelerates private aspiration and reduces the time available for slower communal practices. The prose does not count how many meetings were missed or measure attendance. "Thinning" is an experienced alteration, not a statistical rate. Its significance lies in the changing organisation of attention and shared time.

Departure for the City and the Closed Threshold

Some young people leave for cities, while the thresholds of some homes remain closed throughout the year. The images join the attainment of employment to domestic absence. The Gulf-migration chapter also juxtaposed improved houses with empty courtyards, but these are not identical situations. Contracts and overseas remittances differ from domestic urban employment and its everyday acceleration. The new geography of departure extends the novel's existing pattern rather than merely repeating it. The text's abbreviated treatment, however, does not present the independent experiences of every household whose door remains shut.

Dinesh's Focalization: Outer Brilliance and the Village Evening Within

Dinesh observes the new speed of urban life and remembers the village's former evenings. The narrative gives him a short inward interval but does not produce a self-contained city scene. The metropolitan world is known chiefly through its reported brilliance, whereas the peepal and village gathering remain concrete points of reference. The resulting focal arrangement keeps the village as the stable centre of interpretation and the city as a changing external environment. This is consistent with the book's larger form, while limiting a genuinely symmetrical portrayal of urban and rural experience.

Conversation at the Peepal: A Second-Order Judgement

Dinesh brings his astonishment at everything being new to Burhbā. The response does not insist that the market should be closed; it advises welcoming new possibilities while protecting one's roots. The chapter's ethical discussion rests upon this dialogue. Dinesh is not, however, granted an extended counterargument to the witness's conclusion. Once again, a near-didactic conversation supplies an authoritative synthesis more swiftly than a sequence of conflicting economic experiences would. This technique provides clarity at the price of reduced independent debate.

The Contradiction Within the Wind-and-Roots Metaphor

The song suggests that a tree whose roots are deep will withstand the wind. Yet the prose shows old gatherings thinning, homes being left closed and desires changing. The village's cultural roots are not immutable elements of nature; they endure only to the extent that people continue the practices associated with them. The metaphor has force as encouragement, but complete faith in its stability may obscure genuine losses within change. The tension between the song's assurance and the prose's unsettling details is more productive than treating them as perfectly congruent statements.

The Song's Collective Certainty and the Prose's Uncertainty

The lyric repeatedly promises that the tree will not be uprooted if its roots remain deep. The prose does not independently establish the preservation of every practice. It shows Dinesh resolving to maintain a relationship with local storytelling. Even the announced continuation of stories through later years is an iterative narrator's statement, not a survey of the memories of every child. The song's mode is assurance; the prose's most meaningful action is effort. This difference makes cultural continuity a matter of responsibility, rather than an outcome secured in advance by destiny.

The Organisation of Storytelling: Renewal Rather Than Rejection

Whenever Dinesh returns from the city, he seats children near the peepal and tells them stories of the tree, pond and old names. The concrete act creates an interval of communal time against the new economic haste. Yet the children's answers, disagreements and questions are not given. Tradition is transmitted, but the future generation's power to revise it remains open. The chapter's conclusion therefore rests less upon an independently proven permanence of roots than on the repeated decision to tell and hear the village's history.

The Functional Difference Between Earlier Migration and Liberalisation

In Chapter [−47], overseas earnings helped transform the village's houses; here liberalisation brings consumer goods into the village and private-sector employment outside it. Both episodes involve young people absent from home, but Gulf construction work and a domestic private-company job differ in institutional and economic setting. The narrative employs "roots" to bring these changes into one thematic family. Such repetition gives the extended novel coherence, yet it also risks treating distinct economic problems as if they were the same. A precise analysis must recognise both the continuity and the adjustment.

Distribution of Characters: Who Speaks for the Beneficiaries of the Market?

Dinesh is a young, educated beneficiary of change. Shopkeepers, farmers, plastics sellers, tailors, itinerant workers and women purchasing the new goods do not receive detailed independent speech. "People began wanting more" is a collective assertion rather than a series of varied accounts of value. The new market is therefore viewed chiefly through a selected young man's employment and Burhbā's ethical interpretation. The novel declares a broad transformation but narrates much of it through one family. The difference between social scope and represented voices deserves critical attention.

The Female Line of Succession and Dinesh's New Centrality

Kusum created a memorial of waiting in Chapter [−47]; the focus now shifts to her son Dinesh. The generational change carries continuity in the duty to remember, but it also alters the narrative assignment of gendered roles. Kusum's actions are concentrated around domestic remembrance and hope; Dinesh moves between employment, market experience and children's education. This distribution should not be elevated into a judgement upon every woman in the novel. It is, nevertheless, a limitation in the focal choices of this particular chapter. The children offer a connection between the two generations.

Cable Television as the Next Stage of Chapter [−48]

The earlier media chapter introduced radio and television and examined the struggle between external broadcasting and the village's own voices. Now the arrival of cable television with many channels expands the number of choices and potentially intensifies the competition for attention. The text does not develop the content of individual programmes or provide a detailed account of how viewers respond. The

recurrence of new media is not merely a list of successive devices. It forms a longer narrative of changing habits of listening, seeing and allocating communal time.

National History Translated into Local Experience

"Economic reform" is the external historical reference; goods, jobs, greater speed and reduced participation at the chaupal are its translation into village life. Instead of depicting national policymakers in Delhi, the narrator makes macroeconomic change a problem in the scheduling and values of local families. This localisation is a significant narrative choice. Yet the fiction alone does not establish the complete economic history through which any particular private job was created. The period marker and the chapter's small number of narrated consequences must remain distinct from comprehensive historical evidence.

The Additional Labour Required to Sustain a Site of Memory

Burhbā's advice is to keep the roots deep. But those roots do not strengthen themselves: Dinesh must return, gather the children and tell the stories. The repeated social work behind remembrance becomes visible in this modest action. It requires time taken from the very economic haste the chapter describes. The most compelling movement is from roots imagined as an immobile object to belonging maintained as an activity in the present. Local identity survives not as a museum piece, but through renewed relationships with people and place.

Temporal Extension: Market Speed and Generational Practice

The opening locates the chapter in 1991 and the rapid spread of market changes. Its middle describes thinning village evenings; the closing invokes year-after-year storytelling. Swift social alteration and slow repeated practice create opposing temporal rhythms. The only comparatively focused dialogue belongs to Dinesh and Burhbā, while most external changes are summarised. There may be relatively few individual incidents, but the changing pace of social time is the chapter's governing issue. Narrative duration and the reader's perception of collective life do not correspond simply to a count of events.

Evaluation: Welcome, Caution and the Problem of Nostalgia

The chapter does not deny the benefit of economic opportunity; Dinesh's job makes that clear. It also registers the erosion of time spent together. Its limitations lie in the narrow portrayal of economic winners and losers and the absence of an independent argument in favour of the new consumer culture. The old village evening comes close to becoming an unquestioned moral ideal, a nostalgia that can conceal earlier inequalities. Nevertheless,

the main idea survives these objections: accepting new instruments also requires a deliberate reorganisation of the practices by which communal memory is sustained.

Source Limits and the Next Connection

This analysis draws on the song "Wind and Roots," the explicit reference to 1991, Dinesh's private-sector employment, cable television, Burhbā's dialogue and the recurrence of storytelling to children. Neither the company's identity nor its pay nor a detailed economic-policy account is given. In the following chapter, the new instrument changes from an object of consumption to the computer, a medium through which the village can begin recording its own history.

Critical Section 57 | Original Chapter −44 — The First Computer

The Coconut-Leaf School: A Place Changes Its Medium

"The First Computer" takes place at the village's Coconut-Leaf School. The new device thus arrives not in an anonymous office but in an institution whose very name preserves the memory of older writing materials. After Dinesh, responsibility for the ritual passes to Pratimā; the generational transition brings the new medium into a continuing tradition of local knowledge. The computer is more than an emblem of modernisation. Its arrival creates an encounter between the school's manuscript heritage and digitally displayed letters. The chosen site joins the novel's remembered geography with a new stage in the history of recording knowledge.

A Grey Machine and Green Letters: The Device's Visible Body

The computer is described as large and grey, with flickering green characters. These physical details make its historical novelty palpable: the steady strokes once associated with writing on a leaf now appear as light on a screen. Children and elderly villagers gather, some calling it magic and others expressing doubt. The narrator presents their responses in a brief collective scene without giving each person a fully developed argument. The device's unfamiliar body becomes the threshold between wonder and the practical education needed to use it.

The First Scene: Silence and a Question Among the Onlookers

People gather around the machine. An elderly observer asks whether an instrument that can preserve letters can also preserve meaning. The speaker is unnamed, but the question provides an immediate counterpoint to fascination. The school does not greet the computer solely with applause; it first confronts the difference between storage and understanding. This doubt is not a crude rejection of technology. It is a narratological device that allows a question about the survival of context and cultural experience to emerge from the spectacle of a new writing surface.

Pratimā's First Typing: A Song's Opening Line, Not an Entire Register

The prose states that Pratimā types the first line of the village's oldest folk song on the computer. It does not say that she digitises the whole novel, an entire register of the dead or even the complete song. The action is highly limited but symbolically decisive: familiar letters enter a new luminous medium, and the children applaud. The narrator may later invoke a vast future for this beginning, but the accomplishment shown in the scene is

one line. Treating potential capacity as an already completed archive would erase the very distinction between event and projection on which the chapter depends.

Pratimā's Sensation: The Song Enters an "Unfamiliar House"

As the letters appear, Pratimā feels as though the song is leaving the coconut leaf and travelling to an unfamiliar home. This is a metaphor within her experience, not an event in which the song physically wanders inside the machine. The new medium creates an emotional estrangement: the language remains her own, yet the place in which it is displayed feels foreign. Through this fleeting internal focalization, the narrative makes the alteration of a recording medium a change in cultural feeling, rather than an exclusively technical matter.

"The Machine Keeps Letters": The Contest Between Speech and Record

The elderly observer's question and Burhbā's answer approach the same problem from different generational positions. A computer can swiftly record characters, but their pronunciation, social occasion, audience and narrative relationships do not preserve themselves. The narrator separates the storing of signs from the communal interpretation that gives them meaning. Yet the two are not declared enemies. Burhbā allows that the device could become a guardian, provided its use meets certain conditions. The issue is thus editorial and social responsibility, not an unconditional rejection of digital writing.

A Declared Lineage from the Poet Haripati to the Computer

Burhbā recalls changes in the means of recording stories since the age of the poet Haripati: paper, the printing press and now the computer. Within a single speech, the long-lived witness brings several chapters and periods together. This sequence is the novel's own genealogy of memory-bearing materials; it is not a complete universal account of technological history. Different media have emerged, but the ownership and interpretation of stories continue to raise related questions. The medium changes more visibly than the conflict over who may make a record and on what terms.

"In Our Own Words": Linguistic Authority Over the Archive

Burhbā welcomes the computer on the condition that village stories remain in the village's words and perspective. The statement recalls the outsider's notebook in Chapter [−57], where a visiting scholar interpreted familiar practices through alienating categories. The problem is therefore not merely leaf versus screen. It concerns the language of the record, the authority of the interpreter and the community's relationship to its own

materials. A device operated with local responsibility can preserve experience; used for reductive classification, it may turn names into disconnected data. This contrast gives the sequence a self-reflexive critical depth.

Succession in the Ritual: Pratimā, Dinesh's Daughter

The transfer of responsibility from father to daughter is important within the family's pattern of succession. Pratimā is not simply an audience member watching the computer arrive. She performs the first act of typing and begins a process of teaching pupils to do the same. Her practical initiative shows that the protection of communal memory is not assigned along one immutable gender line. Nevertheless, the personal work of other women teachers, collectors and singers is not described. One representative figure compresses a larger field of memory-work into her own activity.

School Pupils: Collective Bearers of a New Form of Writing

After the initial event, pupils learn to type fragments of songs and stories. The scene therefore moves from Pratimā's individual action to the beginning of shared instruction. The chapter does not give a pupil-by-pupil record of dates and texts, but the activity is clearly established. A newly introduced device acquires cultural use rather than remaining an object of public astonishment. Such transmission is consistent with the Coconut-Leaf School's recurring role in the novel: skills learned in one generation become capacities that later communities can exercise under changed circumstances.

Rapid Counting and the Living Story Behind a Name

The song repeats the idea that the machine counts quickly, whereas a name is not merely a number. Behind a name lies suffering, relationship, utterance and a particular history. Burhbā does not dismiss digits or written characters; he requires the record to preserve the significance of the people to whom those signs refer. Counting, digital lists and spoken remembrance are therefore not simple substitutes for one another. The practical event-sequence—machine arrives, Pratimā types a line, children applaud, pupils learn—must be distinguished from the conceptual question of the future archive. The small action opens a large cultural possibility without completing it.

The Narrator's Glimpse Ahead: “Many Years Later”

The final prose announces that the small beginning will become a complete digital archive many years later. This is explicit prolepsis, not an archive already finished in the chapter under review. If the future

statement were converted into a current result, the text's distinction between narrated accomplishment and projected development would disappear. Here the narrator claims knowledge beyond that of the characters at the initial demonstration. A reader must still consider how later chapters represent the actual capacities, failures and risks of that archive.

Earlier Printing Conflicts Transformed by Technology

Chapter [−63] discussed the printing press, Chapter [−57] an outsider's printed representation, and Chapter [−44] the computer. Together they make a sequence of concerns about the recording of stories. The first problem was when to fix a still-growing narrative; the second, the distortion of its meaning; the third, the storing of words in a new format. This is not a simple ladder of technological progress. The possibility of communal control and the risk of misrepresentation persist across media, appearing in altered material forms.

Leaf, Paper and Screen: Materials Under Transformation

The song says that whether the surface is a leaf or screen, the status of the names remains central. The prose gives these materials distinct sensory qualities: a leaf can be touched, while the screen depends upon illuminated characters. The narrator does not explain power dependence, technical copies, long-term data integrity or the mechanics of preservation. The passage is therefore an initial literary encounter with digital writing, not a handbook of electronic archiving. Its interest lies in how changing material surfaces alter the emotional and social perception of an old story.

Digital “Magic” and Burhbā's Extraordinary Existence

Some villagers call the computer magic, while Burhbā himself belongs to the novel's magical-realist order as a witness across exceptional stretches of time. These are two different forms of wonder. The unfamiliar efficiency of an instrument is not the same ontological phenomenon as Burhbā's presence in the fictional world. A shared vocabulary of amazement cannot collapse the distinction between them. Instead, the scene shows a community capable of approaching both technical novelty and its inherited supernatural witness with curiosity, while their narrative functions remain distinct.

Local Onlookers and the Possibility of Future Readers Across the World

The first computer is seen by villagers and pupils. The promised digital collection suggests an eventual readership beyond the school, perhaps far beyond the village. But such readers are not present in the episode, and

their language, access rights and interpretative powers are not described. Pratimā and her pupils possess an early local practice, not a demonstrably universal public archive. The suspended future allows the excitement of possibility while requiring judgement on the ultimate social outcome to remain provisional.

The Elder's Question Remains Difficult

Burhbā responds to "Can it preserve meaning?" by setting out ethical conditions. He does not explain exactly how the machine itself would understand a song, how future readers would recover its context, or how a melody could survive if the singing community disappeared. Typing one line succeeds as writing; it is not the successful digitisation of sound, performance and all the relationships belonging to a tradition. This incompletion is not an excuse to dismiss the episode. It is precisely the question that keeps its critical significance alive beyond the initial demonstration.

Evaluation: A Small Beginning and an Ambitious Self-Reflective Horizon

The act of typing one line is modest; the issues surrounding it concern an entire history of narrative authority. That disproportion is both the chapter's aesthetic strength and its limit. A complete future digital archive is announced but its creation is not yet dramatized. The pupils begin to become a new generation of guardians, while the machine can only serve as such a guardian if community control and meaning remain central. The chapter is effective as an account of technical possibility informed by cultural responsibility, not as a completed solution.

Primary Material and Questions for Further Study

This reading is based on the song "Machine and Meaning," the arrival of the grey computer, Pratimā's first line of typing, the elder's question, Burhbā's reply and the future-oriented closing statement. The chapter does not yet describe a complete digital repository, infallible name-preservation, its ownership, errors or universal access. The following episode turns from the question of keeping names to the material environmental conditions needed to sustain the people who remember them.

Critical Section 58 | Original Chapter −43 — The Diminishing River

The Flooding River Is Now Thirsty: A Reversal of Narrative Substance

The Kamala-Balan, which in several earlier sections swept away houses and threatened the village, now appears as a river with falling water levels. Older inhabitants remember the current reaching the embankments during the rains; in summer, banks of sand have become visible. This alteration makes the river an active subject of the narrative rather than a static setting. The movement from excessive water to inadequate water is not merely a seasonal description. It changes the ethical force of the novel's remembered geography. The reader measures the irony of the diminishing current against the floods that once made the same river terrifying.

The Narrative Duration of a Slow Calamity

Flood and fire commonly arrive as sudden events concentrated within a night or a few scenes. The river's diminution, by contrast, proceeds "year after year." Its outward event-density is lower, but its duration is much longer. Exposed sand, deepening wells and declining catches accumulate into signs of a process. There is no sudden announcement followed by instant restoration. Older villagers first recognise the changes; Satyanarayan then articulates the danger, and intervention begins. The slow movement of environmental time creates a different kind of narrative pressure from that generated by spectacular disaster.

The Personification of Water: "Thirsty Itself"

The song "The Thirsty Current" turns the river from a giver of water into a creature requiring water. A river literally feeling thirst is a poetic personification, not a scientific proposition. The prose instead presents visible material symptoms: falling water levels, sand, fewer fish and changes in pond water. The two levels reverse the reader's habitual perception. What once threatened people through excess now requires their care for its preservation. The lyric's symbolic river and the prose's physical observations are complementary, but their evidentiary status is not identical.

Limits of the Narrative's Environmental Causal Claims

The narrator mentions deforestation and pollution from distant factories reaching the river. These are causes suggested within the fictional account. No specific industry, waste discharge, hydrological measurement or dated scientific series is provided. The chapter does not establish through

quantitative analysis that the entire loss of water resulted exclusively from those factors. Their literary significance is substantial: human economic activity becomes implicated in the deterioration of a previously feared natural force. Critical discussion must nonetheless avoid converting a source-based causal suggestion into an independently established scientific conclusion.

Declining Fish and the Earlier Memory of Sonma Majhin

The narrator observes that fish no longer fill the nets as they formerly did. Fishing labour and the river's condition meet within that single comparison. Sonma Majhin's inherited knowledge is recalled in Burhbā's dialogue, where patience and respectful offerings once informed relations with the water. Yet the present fishing families are not given independent speech, and their lost earnings or changing methods are not developed. The social importance of the river's decline is evident, but the detailed account of its effect upon individual livelihoods remains incomplete. Remembrance supplies an ethical frame without replacing present testimony.

Pond, Well and River: Different Conditions Within One Waterscape

In summer the pond turns greenish-black, wells must be dug deeper and exposed sand spreads along the river. These are not interchangeable descriptions. They refer respectively to standing water, access to groundwater and the volume of a flowing river. To merge them all under a general label of drought would weaken the novel's spatial specificity. The varied conditions suggest the breadth of environmental change, even though the text supplies neither a hydrological map nor measurements connecting the sites. The specificity of the places is part of the narrative's environmental structure.

Satyanarayan: A New Generation Reads the Environment

Pratimā's son Satyanarayan tells Burhbā that Jorī Pond has become smaller and the waters associated with the original crocodile are diminishing. He does more than bring news. He observes changes and begins to frame them as a possible illness of nature. The generational movement from Pratimā's computer to her son's environmental concern juxtaposes different kinds of preservation. A younger inhabitant sees alterations within his own lifetime; Burhbā connects them to longer collective experience. Together these modes of attention provide the basis for subsequent action.

Burhbā's “New Crocodile”: A Major Transformation of the Metaphor

Burhbā speaks of a new crocodile that drinks the water, pollutes the air and consumes the soil. This is a metaphor for forces that destroy the natural

world, not the discovery of another biological species. The novel's central image expands. The earlier crocodile could take a body but not the name preserved in memory; now environmental devastation threatens the very land and water that sustain a remembering community. The stakes change from protecting recollection after death to preserving the material conditions of life. Taking the metaphor as an actual new animal would obscure this fundamental reorientation.

From Protecting Memory to Protecting Resources: The Ethical Programme Expands

Burhbā's decisive argument is that the village must save water as well as names. Earlier chapters focused on lists of the dead, oral traditions and institutional records. The object of protection now includes the resources upon which living people depend. This is more than a slogan asserting that names survive if the village survives. It asks where a community capable of remembering could live if water, forests and soil were destroyed. The long narrative thereby recognises an important condition and potential limit of its original commitment to memory.

The Original Crocodile's Uncertain Relation to Water

Satyanarayan speaks of the diminishing water of the original crocodile, joining a folkloric being, its habitat and the condition of the river. The chapter does not stage a direct appearance by the crocodile, record its response or provide an account of its biological state. “The original crocodile's water” denotes a threatened waterscape within the story's symbolic vocabulary. The creature does not become a speaking interlocutor here. This delimitation matters to the balance between magical realism and environmental observation that the passage maintains.

“It Is Not for Want of Offerings”: Tradition Reconsidered

Recalling Sonma Majhin's practices of offering and patience, Burhbā says that the present crisis has not arisen simply because the community failed to offer something. He calls it a wrong done to nature. Older ritual relations are respected, but they no longer constitute a sufficient response. Deforestation and changing water conditions require tree planting, conservation and care of pond embankments. The passage opens a new space where inherited cultural knowledge can inform modern practical action. There is a tension, however, between calling the harm a wrong of nature and the earlier suggestion that human clearing and pollution contribute to it.

Planting Trees Around the Channā Grove

Satyanarayan begins planting new trees around the channā grove. Trees had previously functioned as memorials to the living and the dead; here they also become possible agents in environmental care. The grove established in Chapter [−70] gains another social use. The narrative does not specify the number of saplings, their species or their survival rates. Planting is an actual action, but completed ecological restoration is not a narrated result. A clear distinction remains between the decision to intervene and the long, uncertain processes upon which the success of that intervention depends.

Pond Embankments and Small Water Channels: Remaking the Landscape

Young villagers strengthen the banks of the pond and dig small channels or catchments to retain rainwater. Thus "save water" changes from an ethical declaration into work performed upon recognisable places. Earlier embankments were associated with defence against floods. The alteration of purpose is striking: the same general kind of earthwork can now be undertaken to preserve scarce water rather than to keep surplus water away. The exact capacity of the channels, their location and duration of effectiveness are not described. The scene records an attempt, not a measured outcome.

A Tree for Every Birth: From Personal Event to Repeated Custom

A new custom is established: a tree is planted whenever a child is born. The arrival of a future human being is associated with the beginning of a future tree. The naming tradition thereby incorporates living environmental matter. The narrator announces the institution of the practice rather than giving a list of separate births and plantings. As elsewhere in the novel, a particular crisis gives rise to an enduring communal form. The ritual's literary importance rests on joining personal continuity with the care of a shared environment.

The First Flood, the Second Flood and the Shrinking Current: Reversal Through Repetition

In Chapters [−89] and [−59], excess river water threatened houses and lives; in Chapter [−43], too little water becomes the danger. The recurrence of the river is therefore a major formal achievement only if its changed meaning is recognised. Water remains a source of crisis, but its mechanisms and the appropriate responses have reversed. A critic who assigns the river one permanently fixed symbolic meaning will miss the

development produced by narrative time. The new condition asks the reader to revise judgements formed during earlier catastrophes.

Depth of Environmental Description, Scarcity of Individual Voices

The exposed sand, darkened pond, falling catch and deeper wells create a persuasive series of sensory indications. Nature is integrated into the story's substance, not left as a scenic backdrop. Yet the experiences of a woman carrying water, a fisherman losing income or a farmer at the edge of the diminishing stream do not become independent narrative scenes. The environmental crisis invites questions about the unequal distribution of social effects, but the chapter does not fully address them. This is a limitation in narrative representation, not evidence that those experiences did not exist within the wider fictional world.

The Didactic Pace of Environmental Reflection

Burhbā speaks at length about the need to conserve water, forests and soil. His long memory becomes linked to a programme of present action. The scale of his ethical explanation is greater than that of the brief scenes showing the work. Satyanarayan's decisions follow quickly, with little representation of disputes about land, resources, labour or agreement. The text establishes a clear moral direction but does not yet develop an intricate political history of communal environmental management. The ratio between discourse and depicted practice is a meaningful feature of its construction.

Time, Expectation and the Unresolved Result

The loss of water had proceeded year after year; tree planting and earthwork begin in response. The chapter does not report that the river rose in the following season or that fish returned to the nets. The song expresses faith that the current will flow again tomorrow, but this is poetic assurance rather than an outcome already narrated. The passage closes upon hopeful action, not on a measured restoration. Its open temporal structure allows the long duration of environmental danger to remain active in the reader's expectations.

Evaluation: Expanding the Novel's Central Condition

“The Diminishing River” broadens the water-burial motif from the danger of excessive water to the danger of its disappearance. The “new crocodile” metaphor exposes the limits of guarding names without guarding their habitat. Satyanarayan's planting, repairs, channels and birth-linked tree custom give tangible form to the response. The weaknesses are the lack of measured causal detail, limited representation of working communities and absence of verified results. Even so, the chapter

makes a major demand upon the long novel's moral universe: for names to endure, the waterscape in which their bearers live must also endure.

Textual Basis and the Question to Follow

This reading draws on "The Thirsty Current," the diminishing Kamala-Balan, the differentiated water sites, Satyanarayan's conversation with Burhbā, tree planting, water-retaining works and the new birth ritual. No quantified scientific river data, measured results of restoration or complete account of individual losses is supplied. The following chapter turns from slow environmental distress to the changing experience of distance and closeness through a digital instrument held in the hand.

Critical Section 59 | Original Chapter −42 — The Miracle of the Handheld Phone

A New Entrance in the Story's Later Phase: The Medium in the Hand

"The Miracle of the Handheld Phone" begins with the arrival of the first mobile phone. Radio and television had previously drawn communal audiences to the chaupal, while the computer stood in the school. The mobile initially appears as one object in the village headman's hand; later it spreads to several households. This change in size and place matters. The centre of communication moves from an assembled audience around a fixed public medium toward rapid conversations initiated by individual hands. The headman's initial possession also suggests unequal access, although the chapter does not provide an exhaustive account of distribution.

"The Distant Comes Near": Distance Narratively Redefined

The opening proverb says that a handheld instrument brings the faraway close, while warning against forgetting the person seated nearby. Its inversion operates on two levels: geographical distance shrinks, but the social distance created by distracted attention may increase. The prose offers examples of both sides: a family member delights in a distant son's voice, while another person neglects someone physically present. To label the telephone simply a curse or a blessing would erase this duality. The changing distribution of attention, not a mechanical judgement on the device, is the passage's finer concern.

The First Ring: A Scene of Communal Wonder

A small device rings in the headman's hand and a son's voice arrives from a distant city. People fill the courtyard, gathering around the instrument. The scene recalls the collective listening that accompanied the first radio, but the content has changed: this is an intimate family relationship rather than anonymous broadcasting. What begins as a private call becomes an object of public curiosity. The son is not personally named in the source; a more specific identity must not be invented. The immediate event is a shared experience of an unfamiliar form of proximity.

Months for a Letter, a Moment for the Phone: Compressed Time

The narrator contrasts the months formerly spent awaiting news by letter with a voice that now reaches the ear in an instant. A letter did not literally carry a voice; it provided information after a delay. The comparison therefore marks a change in the duration of waiting and reaction. With the phone, an event elsewhere and a response in the village

can occur almost simultaneously. This transformation encourages the reader to reinterpret earlier narratives of long absence. Neither the exact distances nor measured communication delays are reported. The point is the altered rhythm of family knowledge.

From the Headman to Households: A Summary of Social Diffusion

The earliest mobile belongs to the headman; "gradually," several families acquire one. A single word compresses a long process of diffusion. The sequence suggests that access begins with someone socially prominent, but the text does not document price, signal coverage, women's ownership or all households' participation. "Several" is not equivalent to "every." The progress of adoption is visible, its complete equality is not established. An accurate reading respects the difference between a change in the village's technology and a verified universal distribution of that technology.

Anjali's Question: Rewriting the Pain of Separation

Satyanarayan's daughter Anjali asks Burhbā whether the grief of the old "call from abroad" will lessen now that relatives overseas can speak with families every day. The question recalls Kusum and Ramesh in Chapter [–47], as well as the novel's longer history of migration. Anjali identifies a real benefit of the new medium. Burhbā agrees before adding a warning. Rather than treating separation as an unalterable fate, the passage asks what new skills of relationship become possible when technology changes the conditions under which absent people are heard.

Burhbā's Two-Part Answer: Acceptance and Caution

Burhbā initially calls the mobile's ability to connect distant people good news. Only then does he advise that those nearby should not become distant in the user's attention. This double response repeats a pattern in the novel's encounters with technology: acceptance accompanied by discernment. Its force is not solely prescriptive, for the prose also shows an instance of joyful reunion through sound and a contrary scene of neglect. Anjali does not offer an extended rebuttal, but her later teaching provides a practical social test of what the witness recommends.

Hearing and Seeing: Whose Face Is Visible?

The song observes that a distant voice comes to the ear while the face does not appear. At the end of the prose, Anjali teaches older people ways of seeing their sons' faces on the phone. These statements may be understood as different stages of the medium's capabilities within the narrative. An initial experience of voice contact is not identical to the later mention of visual communication. Nor is a complete, successful video call by a named elderly person actually depicted. Teaching how to use a facility must

remain distinct from an independently narrated instance of its successful use.

The Elderly Mother's Tears at Her Distant Son's Voice

An elderly woman whose son has lived in a Gulf country for many years weeps with happiness on hearing his voice through the telephone. This is the chapter's most bodily and affecting moment. The woman's name, her son's name and the complete words of their conversation are absent. Yet the single small scene gives the device an experiential value that abstract praise could not supply. The tears arise from momentary auditory contact after a long separation; they are evidence of what the phone means for this character, not proof that all the difficulties of migration have ended.

The Marker of Waiting in Chapter [–47] and Auditory Presence Now

Kusum earlier placed a marker in hope of Ramesh's safe return. The mobile chapter offers a way to shorten the felt interval of waiting through the immediate arrival of a voice. A physical sign in the village's landscape and a real-time call represent different ways of sustaining ties with an absent body. The phone does not automatically replace the marker, for relationships also depend on remembered histories and the possibility of return. Through this intertextual connection, “name” means not just a written entry but an active, audible relation between persons.

Neglecting the Person Nearby: The Contrary Scene

The narrator observes that some people become so absorbed in conversations with distant acquaintances that they forget those seated beside them. The problem of mobile communication thus acquires a visible social form. It does not follow that every household becomes divided or that the instrument uniformly destroys intimacy. The prose offers a “new scene,” not a universal outcome. One ear attends to a distant voice while a nearby face becomes invisible to the listener. This opposition is the title's miracle turned into an unsettling question about presence and attention.

An Object in the Hand and the Public Chaupal: Competition Between Places

The phone fits into an individual's hand; the chaupal is a place of shared listening and speaking. Personal conversations may increase even as the time available for common storytelling declines. Anjali's final teaching attempts to reconcile those demands: learn to use the phone, but do not abandon face-to-face contact. The older forms of community are not to be destroyed; they are to coexist with the new medium. The text does not offer a longitudinal account proving that all later generations actually

continue gathering. The practical result is a proposed social habit, not total success secured in perpetuity.

Anjali's Teaching: Technical Knowledge Returns Across Generations

Anjali teaches older villagers how to operate the phone. In earlier chapters Burhbā regularly instructed younger people in names, traditions and remembrance. Here a young woman conveys technical knowledge to elders. The direction of teaching reverses, even while the long-lived witness continues providing ethical guidance. This reciprocity is a rich possibility within the novel's intergenerational pattern: inherited memory and new skills can make the generations mutually necessary. Anjali is not merely a recipient of counsel; she performs a concrete act of education.

Gender and the Unspoken Arrangements of Care

The elderly mother's longing and Anjali's instruction place emotional and practical care largely in the hands of female characters. Men working far away become audible, while the detailed burdens borne by people maintaining households at home are less developed. The mother's tears are more than an ornamental image of sorrow: they reveal the significance of contact from her position. Criticism must recognise that role without inventing elaborate accounts of domestic labour, control of the phone or family conflict not supplied by the prose.

The Phone's "Illusion": A Metaphor of Relationships, Not a Philosophical Diagnosis

Burhbā calls the instrument's capacity to make a nearby person seem far away its greatest "illusion." Here the term concerns a mistaken priority of attention rather than a formally established philosophical category of perceptual error. It may echo the shell-and-silver discussion near the novel's beginning, but the present matter is social: who is heard, and who is overlooked? To convert the metaphor into a separate treatise on illusion would obscure the directly narrated question of how communication rearranges relationships.

The Pace of Instant News: Both Joy and Distress

News of marriages, illness and everyday events can now travel within moments. The mobile creates an enlarged family present in which joy and anxiety may be shared more promptly. Delays associated with letters and travel had previously extended periods of uncertainty. The text, however, does not develop a full dramatic exchange for each kind of message listed. Its abbreviated catalogue indicates a change in narrative and social time, not a complete chronicle of particular households. The rapid circulation of information permits several different emotional consequences.

The Two Voices of the Song "Near and Far"

The song first celebrates the distant voice arriving miraculously, then worries about the neglect of the person close at hand, and finally calls for reconciliation. The prose broadly follows this movement through the headman's call, the elderly mother's tears, scenes of distracted attention and Anjali's teaching. Song and prose correspond here more closely than in many earlier chapters, but not without qualification. The lyric's claim that the machine has broken nearby relationships must not be converted into universal fact when the prose describes a limited pattern of neglect and an attempt to address it.

The New World's Interpreter: Burhbā's Continuing Authority

Burhbā understands the benefits of the device, yet he once again supplies the conclusive ethical formulation. Kusum in Chapter [−48], Pratimā in Chapter [−44], and Anjali here are all practical female innovators whose actions remain partly framed by Burhbā's recurring counsel. That consistency gives the long narrative a recognisable intellectual centre, but also constrains the independent presentation of opposing views. The mobile's direct users do not conduct a lengthy debate with the witness. The formal achievement of continuity and the limitation of concentrated authority operate together.

The Time Sequence of Technologies and the Reading That Follows

The chapter places the mobile's arrival in Satyanarayan's era. Kusum's telephone contact from overseas in Chapter [−47] is not an inconsistency merely because the handheld mobile appears later: a fixed-line telephone and a mobile phone are different instruments. The computer's arrival at the school in Chapter [−44] also belongs to a different institutional setting. Without examining such distinctions, a critic might manufacture a chronological defect. The exact forms, places and uses of technology must be identified before determining whether the narrative's time sequence conflicts with itself.

Not Complete Protection but the Beginning of Social Education

Anjali teaches phone use while encouraging the preservation of face-to-face relationships. Her instruction does not establish that every harmful effect of mobile communication has been removed. The chapter provides a practical proposal for communal conduct rather than its final, exhaustive result. This open ending is appropriate to a set of problems involving attention, privacy and relationships which cannot be resolved simply by a single admonition. The new medium opens questions that will remain relevant in the novel's developing digital world.

Overall Evaluation: The Changing Measure of Nearness

The chapter's strength is its refusal to make technology either hero or villain. The elderly mother's tears and the neglect of a nearby person give both possibilities bodily form. Anjali's teaching shows a path toward social appropriation of the new instrument. Weaknesses remain: the mother and son are unnamed, unequal access is not developed, and Burhbā's judgement receives little independent challenge. Nevertheless, the altered meanings of distance and proximity enter the narrative's emotional life and provide a crucial question for subsequent experiences of digital communication.

Primary Sources, Textual Limits and the Next Sequence

The primary materials are the song "Near and Far," the headman's first handheld phone, the elderly mother's hearing of her distant son, Anjali's question, Burhbā's response and the closing account of instruction. The prose does not specify the phone's price, network availability, a full individual video-call scene or comprehensive household adoption figures. The next section, Chapter [–41], "The City's Market," extends these concerns into the experience of urban employment and changing identities.

Critical Section 60 | Original Chapter −41 — The City's Market

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

A New Recurrence of Migration: The Earlier Story in a New Industry

Chapter [−41] brings the urban information-technology industry into the long history of migration from Garh Narikel. Chapter [−47] concerned Gulf construction work and the distant relationship between Kusum and Ramesh; here software employment in Bangalore, Hyderabad, and Delhi initiates the narrative. In both episodes young villagers leave in pursuit of economic opportunity, but the kind of work, education, and conditions of communication differ. Rather than merely repeat an event, the narrator attempts to show how the earlier pain takes a different form as historical circumstances change. The daily experience of work in the city, however, remains almost entirely outside this chapter.

The Narrative Opening: Collective Summary, Not an Individual Scene

The first narrative movement reports that numerous educated young people from the village find jobs in metropolitan cities. A single paragraph compresses the prolonged movement from learning letters at the village school, through acquiring the language of computers, to gaining employment. It offers no separate scenes of recruitment interviews, failed training, or metropolitan offices. Such temporal compression accords with the novel's vast generational sequence, but it also tends to reduce the social experience of labour to collective achievement. The reader initially encounters the group called “the young people”; a particular point of view emerges only later through Karunakar.

“The City Buys the Body”: The Song's Metaphor and the Prose's Facts

The introductory proverb represents the market as a purchaser of bodies. The song “Roots and the Market” likewise describes exchanging working time, sweat, and money as selling the body. The prose, however, makes clear that educated young people are undertaking software work and modern employment; it does not recount anyone literally selling their body. The metaphor permits criticism of the commodification of labour, but transforming it into an actual episode of bodily sale or a definitively documented form of exploitation would contradict the text. The distance between the song's moral severity and the narrator's qualified optimism about employment must remain visible.

Pride Alongside Emptiness: The Double Movement of Social Perception

The village's households take pride in their educated children's advancement; yet festivals now find the young in the cities, and many houses stand locked. The two images do different work. The first summarises public accomplishment; the second gives everyday absence a visible sign. A padlocked threshold stands in for an absent person. The narrative does not provide an account of incoming money but conveys the emotional cost through this domestic image. Among the unnamed households, however, the voices of elderly people, women, and children are not separately heard. The experience of loss remains largely inside collective narration.

From Anjali to Karunakar: The Art of Genealogical Introduction

In Chapter [−42], Anjali taught people to use mobile phones; here her son Karunakar carries the metropolitan experience. He is introduced through descent before his independent characterisation begins. In a very long novel, such entrances help readers maintain connections across numerous generations, though repeated introductions as someone's son or daughter can delay the new character's autonomy. Karunakar's primary distinction is not simply education but his capacity to question his own emotional distance. His question subjects the previous generation's teaching to a fresh experiential test.

Karunakar's Admission: From External Success to Inner Incongruity

Karunakar says that he has learned much in the city, yet in the same breath fears that he is being severed from his roots. The pain here is not merely an object of the narrator's description: the character interprets his own condition. A phrase such as "I feel" maintains the difference between subjective apprehension and an established fact about his life. The novel does not authoritatively declare that the city has socially cut him off. His question holds the meaning open, while Burhbā's response attempts to turn uncertainty into cultural reassurance.

Roots Being Cut and Moving Away from Roots: A Spatial Grammar

Burhbā distinguishes the cutting of roots from moving away from them. This botanical metaphor changes the narrative geography: the village need not remain a physical prison, but becomes the centre of remembered relationships. The image of roots extending outward makes departure a potential expansion rather than an absolute prohibition. Botanical extension and a person's annual return are nevertheless unlike processes. The novel employs their resemblance as an emotional analogy, not a

literal natural law. Its force lies in imagining a new relationship with the past.

The Company's Tall Building: A Brief Interior Focalisation

The prose shows Karunakar seated in a tall company building and remembering the village's peepal, pond, and communal square. This is a rare entry into his inner world. The height of the urban building implicitly contrasts with the depth of the village's roots. A pang of loss is suggested, but not developed into a complete psychological history. During his annual return the pang subsides "for a little while"; that temporal qualification matters. The text does not claim that a renewed tie with memory permanently cures modern loneliness.

"One Evening in a Year": An Unusual Covenant of Narrative Time

The song and Burhbā's answer both present one evening each year beneath the peepal as a minimal thread of continuing attachment. The many months of urban economic life drop out of narration, while the village evening receives exceptional illumination through storytelling. Thus a long city life is compressed and a brief visit becomes semantically dense. The disproportion grants the village a privileged narrative place. One evening, however, cannot itself answer every question of social care, support for elders, or economic dependence resulting from migration.

From an Individual Return to a Collective Tradition

Karunakar spends an evening of his leave under the peepal. He tells children about the city, and they tell him the village's old stories. Later, the narrator says, this becomes an unwritten tradition for numerous young people. The transformation of personal experience into collective recurrence is the chapter's actual final change of state. Yet there are no individual names of the other participants, no scene of the first repetition, and no separately voiced contrary experience. The claim of an emerging institution comes through a brief concluding summary. It works as literature without amounting to a complete sociological demonstration.

Reversed Communication: Children Are Not Merely Listeners

Under the peepal Karunakar shares his urban experiences with the children, who in turn recount the old village stories to him. Teaching is therefore not one-directional: the adult migrant from the city also becomes a new listener to village memory. That memory does not survive solely as the fixed utterance of an ancient teacher; it is transmitted in younger voices. Nevertheless, these children are not given distinct names or an independent opportunity to disagree. Reciprocal storytelling is an achievement, but actual plurality within the dialogue remains limited.

The Peepal as Narrative Site: A Stable Centre Against Distance

Employment, festivals, and private life change rapidly in the city, but the returning place is still the peepal. Its continuity preserves a physical point of reference for Burhbā's long memory. For the person who has changed, the site helps reassemble identity and makes "home" larger than a single building. Its poetic value is clear. Yet the chapter does not establish whether people of every caste, class, or gender can access that gathering place with equal ease. Its assumed inclusiveness requires examination against the social scenes of the larger novel.

Distribution of Voices: Burhbā Decides, the Urban World Is Silent

Karunakar expresses his anxiety and Burhbā supplies an extensive answer. Colleagues at the company, urban neighbours, workers' organisations, and the conditions of employment receive no independent voices. The result is not a many-sided account of migration but a dialogue oriented towards the village. Burhbā's reply is affectionate, yet questions remain: how much leave is available, and how can a poor migrant afford the journey home? Raising these issues does not add events to the source; it evaluates what its selected mode of narration leaves unspoken.

Differences of Class Within Collective Village Pride

At the opening, pride is attributed to "every household," while the people obtaining jobs belong specifically to the group of "educated young people." Access to software work cannot therefore be treated as an achievement available to every household on identical terms. The village school is a long-standing resource in the novel, but the prospects of young people denied higher education are not described here. This absence limits the chapter's depiction of inequalities within the new market. Critical reading must not mistake a collective statement of enthusiasm for evidence about the distribution of employment across the entire society.

A Narrative Triangle with Chapters [−47] and [−42]

Ramesh's migration to the Gulf and Kusum's waiting in [−47], Anjali's instruction in mobile telephony in [−42], and Karunakar's return from the metropolis in [−41] together form a history of changing distance. The first involves money, letters, and infrequent telephone contact; the second an immediately audible voice; the third a repeated physical return to the original place. These are not one generation's experiences but three conditions of migrant relationships. Nor do they form a simple ladder of progress: despite easier communication, Karunakar still feels the pang of estrangement.

The Song's Injunction and the Prose's Indeterminacy

"Roots and the Market" repeatedly enjoins people to preserve the names of home and depicts someone who sells that name returning empty-handed. In the prose Karunakar has not lost his name; he only fears being cut off. The song treats possible moral destruction almost as a completed outcome, while the prose renders it an experiential question. To interpret them as identical reports would erase the chapter's subtlety. Their difference is not necessarily a fatal inconsistency: the song speaks in the wider language of risk, the prose in the narrower language of an individual's ambivalence.

Critical Judgement: Protecting Relationships, Leaving Labour Unread

The chapter succeeds in refusing to make education or migration natural villains, seeking instead a fresh means of maintaining the right to memory alongside them. Karunakar's passing pang and his yearly meeting under the peepal establish a credible emotional centre. Its limitations are that urban working life, domestic loneliness, and class inequality remain largely within the narrator's summaries. Burhbā's balanced counsel closes the episode without resolving every complication of the urban–rural relationship. Its place in the wider trilogy is to open another variation on "distance and name."

Textual Limits and the Next Link

This analysis is based only on the proverb, "Roots and the Market," the account of migrant employment, Anjali's relationship to Karunakar, the dialogue under the peepal, and the unwritten annual practice in original Chapter [−41]. The text provides no particular wages, illness, accidents, company exploitation, or definitive reckoning of household finances; none has been supplied by the criticism. In [−40], the narrative moves from the personal remembrance of migrant names to the public right to government records.

Critical Section 61 | Original Chapter −40 — The Right to Information

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

The Arrival of a Right: A Government Measure Becomes Narrative

"The Right to Information" opens with a general report of legal change, but the village's history immediately gives that external announcement a particular communal meaning. Yādavānanda's Shadow Register had been preserved in hiding for many years; now the possibility arises of obtaining old records from government offices by application. Law is thus not an unrelated historical fact but a consequence, within the story, of its previously established history of secret writing. The novel does not describe parliamentary debate, the passage of the legislation, or a specific date. It chooses the measure's social effect.

Yādavānanda's Register: Reactivating a Suspended Earlier Event

Mentioning the Shadow Register does more than decorate the episode with background. The writing once carried out secretly, to withstand fear, can now be compared with legally obtained documents. In this return, the novel's long duration is reorganised: past secrecy becomes the initial basis of a new public right. Readers who remember Yādavānanda's episode can grasp the added significance of [−40]. The complete contents of the register and the number of surviving pages, however, are not reproduced. Its continuity is largely asserted by the narrator in collective terms.

The "Lamp" Metaphor: What Is the Enemy Called Darkness?

The opening proverb calls information a lamp. Darkness here is not literal night but unequal control of archives. The distance between an official's cupboard and a citizen's hand becomes an ethical distance between narrative places. Light signifies access to public knowledge, not the automatic remedy of every historical wrong. The metaphor's clarity also has a cost: difficulties of reading complicated files, resolving contradictory names, or understanding administrative language scarcely enter the chapter. This simplification is partly generated by its chosen image of illumination.

Office and Village: The Journey of a Paper Between Narrative Sites

The prose traces government archival papers as they come into the village. The object crossing the distance is a document rather than a person. Requests, receipt, a yellowed sheet held in a hand, and comparison with

the register make the paper an active narrative object rather than inert material. Yet Vibhā's journey through office queues, conversations with officials, fees, and delays is not staged separately. The narrator compresses administrative labour to focus on the decisive encounter: secret village records and government records placed face to face.

"Face to Face": A Dialogue Between Documents Rather Than People

Government papers and the Shadow Register are laid opposite each other. Two documents become, figuratively, two witnesses. The narrator does not simply replace the state's account with village oral memory; papers from different institutional positions are subjected to comparison. "Truth" is given a material form beyond a single assertion by the narrator. Nevertheless, no difficult scene shows Vibhā deciding between conflicting records. The work of comparison turns readily into endorsement. An arduous inquiry that could have been dramatised is considerably shortened.

Vibhā's Intervention: A New Right for a New Generation

Karunakar's daughter Vibhā transforms the inheritance of secret writing into an exercisable right. She is not merely Burhbā's listener: she requests official records, receives them, and gathers them. Her assertion that there is no longer a need to keep the register hidden conveys the confidence of her generation. Burhbā quickly affirms that confidence, however, leaving unanswered whether independent village records could still matter if official documents again proved false. Her action is concrete, while the enduring independence of the archive remains insufficiently tested.

The First Paper: Yellow, Torn, Bearing Written Names

The government record placed in Vibhā's hand is described as "yellowed, torn." This brief material detail shows long administrative time in the vulnerable body of paper. Finding the same name in the Shadow Register gives her a private satisfaction. Correspondence between names is not, by itself, a complete resolution of land injustice or every question of historical truth; it is a limited agreement given decisive emotional significance. The chapter does not reproduce the specific name, land entry, or dispute recorded on that page.

"Each Confirms the Other": The Limit of the Narrator's Conclusion

The narrator treats the agreement between official papers and the Shadow Register as mutual corroboration. At the literary level, this is a triumph ending a long wait. Yet matching some names cannot establish the infallibility of every page. The critic's task here is not a separate judicial proof test but to measure the extent of the narrator's certainty. The reader

sees a restricted scene, while the final declaration enlarges it into a "complete, legally recognised historical collection." The leap from demonstrated correspondence to exhaustive outcome is narratologically substantial.

"No Official Can Erase It": The Resolute Final Declaration

The concluding sentence describes the durability of the right in almost absolute terms. Its emotional purpose is clear: the movement from Yādavānanda's fearful era to Vibhā's era of rights should feel complete. But the novel does not separately establish that documents can never be corrupted, destroyed, reinterpreted, or obstructed by administrative difficulties. Such total wording is the victory song of the final prose, not a factual guarantee of everlasting preservation. Narrative decisiveness and historical uncertainty therefore remain subtly distinct.

The Song's "Poor Person's Hand" and the Social Position of the Characters

The song announces that information has reached the hand of the poor. The prose depicts Vibhā and village youths taking action, not the individual applications of a named landless person, Dalit citizen, or elder. The song's collective democratic claim expresses a literary ideal, not documented participation by every social group. This question of representation matters especially because earlier archival wrongs had been tied to unequal power. The broad declaration of inclusion leaves untested the possible disparities in reaching a government office.

The Office Seal and the Village Voice: A Changed Relation to Legitimacy

In [–57], an outsider's book distorted the village's meanings; here official papers support the local register through correspondence. "Writing from outside" therefore has no single function. The earlier instance was an external interpretation, the present one an administrative record. The novel does not reject every outside text but tests its relation to the village's account of itself. This is a significant maturation across the long narrative, although the final harmony does not continue to explore potential prejudice within official archives.

The Ratio of Scene to Summary: Rapid Achievement

The youths' requests for numerous papers are collectively summarised; Vibhā's receipt of the first yellowed sheet becomes a scene; then the obtaining and collection of "every old record" expands once more into a sweeping summary. The three-part sequence—introduction, emotional incident, institutional conclusion—creates speed. Hundreds of possible

days of applications, disputes, or unavailable pages remain unnarrated. The difficult duration of human persistence disappears into compression, while the image of a transformative achievement dominates.

The Right to Ask Questions: A Transformation of Reading

The capacity "to ask" becomes more than an administrative convenience; it changes the reader's position. Yādavānanda's secret recordkeeping invited sympathy for concealed courage, whereas Vibhā's era asks the reader to recognise the legitimacy of public questioning. Literature here models a basic right to interrogate records. Yet establishing an equal relationship between citizen questions and state answers is more complicated than matching two registers. The narrative leaves much of that process unstaged.

From Shadow to Light: A New Meaning for the Earlier Lamp

The electric lamp in [−53] signified physical illumination; the extinguished lamp of the Emergency in [−50] suggested the loss of public freedom of assembly; here the information-lamp symbolises archival transparency. The recurring image of light does not signify the same object or social condition. It denotes technology, threatened rights, and access to knowledge in turn. This variation links distant parts of the novel. Excessive confidence in the symbol can, however, obscure how administrative writing might itself produce darkness. The question remains open.

The Silence of Original Participants: Where Are the Officials?

Law is mentioned and government archives yield documents, but no official is directly heard speaking. The state remains an abstract institutional presence. Vibhā, the active village participant, is named; the officials who hand over documents remain anonymous. This allocates heroism to citizens while concealing the human variations of administrative power. Whether an official resisted, assisted, or remained neutral is not specified by the prose, and cannot be inferred as an event.

An Intertextual Arc: From the Memory of Justice to Public Questioning

The Shadow Register, land rights, omitted names, and the humiliations of previous archival practices are more than accidental background. Yādavānanda's recovered record can be read alongside the search for justice in [−64] and the land-reform outcome in [−54]. But [−40] does not reopen or determine those particular lawsuits. The long generational journey of documents finds another medium; it does not become a book conclusively closing every earlier legal dispute.

Critical Assessment: A Narrative Victory for Material Records

The chapter's achievement lies in giving the abstraction "information" the tangible form of yellowed paper, hands, cupboards, and two registers facing one another. Vibhā emerges as a woman of the new generation capable of decision and action. Its limits are the missing inventory of documents, conflicting pages, differences of caste interest, and procedural difficulties; the announcement of "complete" history exceeds what the scene shows. Still, it marks a decisive passage in the novel's triangle of memory, written record, and state authority.

Source Note and the Next Narrative Connection

This reading draws on the "Lamp of Information" song, the Karunakar–Vibhā generational transition, the requests for archives, Yādavānanda's register, and the final comparison in original [–40]. The specific identification numbers, total number of sheets, and independent verification of the government records are unavailable. In [–39], the written accounting of "every name" enters a new arena: the distribution of wages and public scrutiny of employment records.

Critical Section 62 | Original Chapter −39 — The Guarantee of Work

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

The Narrative Arrival of the Right to Work

Chapter [−39] advances from a citizen's right to know to a worker's right to work. In [−40], Vibhā requested old land records; here her husband Suresh coordinates a scheme locally. Both sections attach importance to public accounts, but the former concerns papers from the past and the latter the names of workers in the present. The arrival of a rural employment-guarantee scheme recalls centuries of migration for labour. The announcement is not itself the decisive event: complications and their resolution during implementation give the chapter narrative form.

Ancestral Memories of Migrants: Bholā, Rāmsevak and Sukhdev

The prose names Bholā, Rāmsevak and Sukhdev, connecting the uncertainty of contemporary workers to older narratives. The significance is not merely that suffering occurred before, but that the absence of secure rights at work remains an unresolved question across a very long span. The text does not say that every present worker descends directly from these three families. Their names construct a symbolic communal genealogy rather than a complete literal family tree. This distinction preserves the difference between intertextual remembrance and biographical evidence.

“Not Alms, but Work”: The Song's Grammar of Dignity

The proverb and “The Right to Work” describe employment as a right rather than a gift. “Attendance” is no longer a merely administrative sign: being recorded by name grants a person formal recognition. The song speaks for the worker's dignity, but the prose does not provide a named worker's separate account of feeling humiliated or defending personal honour. It takes up a declarative voice on behalf of workers, while directly audible workers' voices are few. The difference between representative song and individually staged speech is central to the narration.

Pond, Embankment and Road: A Geography of Labour

Digging ponds, building embankments, and making roads tie the list of jobs to the village's physical landscape. Waterscapes are more than natural scenery: they become material sites of paid work. During earlier floods embankments were needed for protection; in drought episodes ponds and wells were conditions of survival; now the same structures provide

employment. Environmental maintenance and livelihoods can therefore become connected. The text, however, does not say exactly which pond was dug, to what depth, or how many days each worker spent there.

The Active Collective: Unnamed Hands and a Named Coordinator

"Village workers" appear as a collective character, while Suresh and Burhbā receive direct dialogue. Workers' hands perform the labour, yet no identifiable worker gives a sustained account of humiliation, hunger, or anger when wages stop. Narrative heroism gathers around the coordinator reading accounts in public. This makes resistance to irregular payment clear, but leaves workers' independent collective decision-making relatively marginal. The allocation of voices is an actual representational limitation, not an assertion that workers had no such feelings.

The Seed of Law: The Recurrence of Burhbā's Counsel

Burhbā compares the law to a seed, and honest implementation to the water and labour needed to make it grow. The old seeds preserved by Sunayanā in [−51] come to mind, but here a seed is an institutional metaphor, not a physical crop. The familiar agricultural analogy translates an abstract statute into village experience. Burhbā's instructive voice repeatedly provides a stable ethical framework, although it also risks compressing a complex problem into an easy opposition between honesty and dishonesty.

"The Money Stopped Along the Way": The Entry of Actual Conflict

The central complication is that some wage payments stop in the middle of one year. Without this interruption the scheme's success could have remained an unquestioned declaration; delayed payment makes the gap between entitlement and practice visible. The wording "some money" gives neither the amount nor the number affected, and the reason for the stoppage is not stated. It would therefore be unjustified to label the event proven corruption: delay, technical difficulties, and deliberate withholding remain possible but unestablished explanations. The narrated conflict concerns a right that has not yet been paid, not an identified criminal.

Public Reading: From Paper to an Audible Collective Scene

Suresh reads aloud each worker's name and account before the village. The written record thus changes from a silent page into speech heard by a public audience. In [−40], official documents moved from the state into Vibhā's hands; here attendance and payment records are voiced in front of the community. The transformation matters because an account read aloud creates listeners and potential scrutiny. The reader is not told which

worker challenged a particular entry, but the public enunciation of names is itself a distinct narrative act.

The Demand for Withheld Payments and Its Conclusion

Suresh presses officials for outstanding wages "until" each eligible person obtains their due. That temporal construction compresses persistence and eventual payment into a single statement. The narrative grammar gives the action a successful conclusion, without showing how many days passed, which applications were submitted, or what particular struggle forced payment. Narrative speed rises here: a potentially long period of deprivation disappears into a summary of the outcome. The contrast between the staged reading of accounts and the rapidly reported resolution shapes the chapter.

Names on Attendance Rolls and Names in Burhbā's Memory

In earlier sections, preserving a name honoured the dead and protected cultural existence. On a muster roll a name is also essential to a living person's daily economic entitlement. The remembered name and the administrative name now illuminate each other: omission can deprive a worker of payment as well as recognition. The long novel's central concern with names thereby enters the apparatus of modern employment policy. Yet the failure of payment itself proves that merely writing a name does not automatically deliver full wages.

Local Employment and the Continuing History of Migration

The song boldly declares that people will no longer need to go abroad or away for work. The prose shows local employment being created, but not that all migration ends, that all young people return, or that urban opportunities disappear. Karunakar's software work in [–41] belongs to a different employment situation. The two chapters need not contradict one another: opportunities vary, and an employment scheme alone does not conclusively end the entire social history of migration. The song's confidence and the complexity of social life must be read separately.

Vibhā's Present Yet Absent Leadership

The episode is located "in Vibhā's time," but the actions and conversations of the scheme belong principally to Suresh. Vibhā was the active female protagonist of [–40], whereas her direct speech is almost absent here. Family continuity remains intact, while narrative attention shifts towards the male coordinator. Female wage workers and the particular pressures upon them also remain largely unrepresented. This shift raises a question about the distance between the novel's communal commitment and the distribution of actual dialogue.

An Echo of "Law and Practice" in Memory

Burhbā recalls Bholā's experience of the court and emphasises the distance between a legal entitlement and its daily benefit. Earlier injustice thus becomes a warning that helps inform a new decision, not an old lawsuit literally tried again. Remembrance is an instrument of present judgement, rather than a heritage object alone. Nevertheless, the recurrent pattern in which Burhbā offers the correct counsel in every new crisis can restrict other characters' opportunities to discover answers independently.

A Ratio of Action-Markings and Real Events

The significant transitions within the chapter are the introduction of the employment scheme, the beginning of local work, recording of attendance, interruption of wages, public reading of accounts, demands made to officials, resumption of payment, and a continuing accounting practice. Every repeated attendance entry is an institutional process, not an additional high-density dramatic incident. Such discrimination of narrative events prevents a mechanical count of action-marked paragraphs from becoming a substitute for literary analysis.

The Limits of Institutional Completeness

The conclusion describes a system in which every worker's wages are assured on time. It sketches an ideal form of administration but gives no independent depiction of later delays, the next year's difficulty, or dissent by particular individuals. The rhetoric of the result places an ethical seal over a potentially long struggle. This is characteristic of the didactic communal novel, but it shortens the difficulty of resistance. The reader can imagine a successful arrangement, while the question of its permanence remains open to subsequent narrative.

Overall Narratological Assessment

The particular achievement of "The Guarantee of Work" is to establish each worker's name, attendance, and payment as a new kind of accounting for life itself. An actual interruption in wages supplies a dramatic test instead of leaving the statutory announcement unchallenged. Its limits are the inequality of voices, uncertain quantities, and sharply compressed resolution. Burhbā's philosophical analogy maintains thematic continuity, but workers' personal language receives far less space. A critical assessment must acknowledge both the advance in labour rights and the limitations of its presentation.

Source Limits and the Next Turn

The primary material is the song "The Right to Work," the employment scheme during Vibhā's period, Suresh's coordination, interrupted

payments, and the public reading of the attendance record in original [−39]. The novel supplies neither the total number of workers nor payment amounts nor an identified perpetrator of wrongdoing. In [−38], public searching for truth on paper moves into the new complexity of screen-based appearances and false online news.

Critical Section 63 | Original Chapter −38 — The Internet's Web

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

From the Handheld Phone to the Network: A New Stage of Media

In [−42], the handheld phone principally brought the distant relative near through a voice. In [−38], inexpensive internet and smartphones place news, pictures, songs, questions, answers, and contact within a single medium. The object may be held in the same hand, but the narrative danger changes: instead of asking only about the distance between relations, the novel asks who makes the information people receive. Nīraj's introduction gives that change a generational form. The narrator begins with the collective spread of technology, then approaches individual uncertainty and a particular rumour.

The Double Meaning of "Web": Connection and Entrapment

"Web" signifies both a network of internet connections and a trap in which someone may be deceived or confused. The fishing world of Garh Narikel earlier gave the net a concrete place among objects of labour; in this modern episode it is principally a communications structure. The double significance pervades the song. Its suggestion that a "name became a number" warns of reduced social relationships, but the prose does not identify any individual's name actually converted into a particular digital number. Metaphor must not be passed off as a narrated case of data theft.

"The Whole World in an Instant": Extreme Compression of Narrative Time

The instant arrival of world news, questions, pictures, and songs represents the effect of accelerated technology. Physical travel, the wait for letters, and time spent at a communal meeting seem compressed into a moment. Against such speed the narrative sets the patience needed to evaluate information. Its central tension is between "quick access" and "slow examination." The mere fact that an answer arrives immediately does not make it true; the characters' questions explicitly resist that assumption. Speed here is a feature of representation, not a guarantee of knowledge.

Truth and Falsehood with the Same Brightness: An Analysis of Display, Not Epistemology

The story says that false news can glitter like truth. This visual resemblance on a screen is its particular difficulty: an attractive falsehood can assume

the appearance of reliable information. The analytical focus here is on narrative presentation, not an independent philosophical theory of valid knowledge. Since the narrator describes the general danger at the outset, the later false message is less an unexpected revelation than a demonstration of an announced threat. The suspense concerns communal response rather than discovering that false information exists.

The Glittering Lives of Others: Internal Comparison

Internet users become dissatisfied with their own lives after seeing the brilliant lives presented by others. This short detail opens the questions of desire and self-evaluation before any more definite fraud. No person's comparison, economic expectation, or psychological condition is individually dramatised; the passage is a collective summary. It would be an addition to the novel to invent a diagnosed mental illness or an elaborate personal history. The narrative raises a problem of the inner life without yet giving it sustained dramatic development.

Unwanted Contact: The Beginning of Gendered Risk

The prose expressly mentions unwanted approaches from strangers to children and young women. Invisible communications technology therefore creates not only problems of true and false reports but unequal risks to bodies and privacy. It does not describe a specific threat to a named person here. That kind of event arrives in [–37]. The order matters: first a general account of danger, then an individual crisis in the next chapter. Reading the latter back into [–38] as if it were already narrated destroys this deliberately progressive arrangement.

Nīraj's Question: An Anxious Participant, Not an Expert

Suresh's son Nīraj calls the internet a new world while admitting his fear of it. He is a questioning citizen, not an expert whose professional command of technology has been established. Burhbā, holder of long memories, responds in the language of older comparisons rather than claiming contemporary technical experience. The dialogue creates intergenerational exchange, although authority over the explanation largely remains with Burhbā. The younger people later give the actual use and examination of messages a practical social form.

The Return of Shell and Silver: An Intertextual Reconstruction

Burhbā links internet deception with the earlier shell-and-silver episode. In [–100], the difference between what was seen and the meaning attributed to it supplied a field for narrative debate; here the difference concerns a visible report and its credibility. Thus the immense novel carries an initial question into the age of screens. Yet the philosophical

shell-and-silver controversy and the social spread of online falsehood are different kinds of incidents. Resemblance in the word "illusion" cannot establish their complete theoretical identity. The intertextual construction is deliberate, but not a proof of perfect philosophical equivalence.

The Mention of Four Means: A Character's Speech and the Critic's Method

Burhbā mentions Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's four means and asks Nīraj to put questions to a report. This belongs to the character's historical and cultural self-understanding. The present reading does not turn the episode into a separate Navya-Nyāya test of evidence; its significance is that Burhbā draws a conversational vocabulary for digital conduct from long cultural memory. Questions such as "Who said it?" become means of prompting critical attention within the story. Their narrative effectiveness is demonstrated only to a limited degree by the young people's subsequent verification group.

One False-News Incident: The Anonymity of Its Details

An inflammatory false report circulates in the village; Nīraj's group searches for its origin and declares it false. The actual wording, subject, sender's name, and intended victims remain unreported. This is therefore not a fully developed mystery about a crime but an exemplary scene of verification. Indeed the narrator tells the reader in advance that the report has no genuine basis. The real investigative process is not dramatised step by step; the reader receives its conclusion and the warning addressed to the village. This limitation concerns narrative density, not the worth of resisting misinformation.

"Spread Like Fire": A Transformation of the Earlier Fire's Language

The rumour spreads "like fire." The literal fire of [−60] involved a lamp, wind, straw, and a human chain carrying water. In [−38], fire is a simile for the rapid movement of a deceptive message. The reader can feel the new danger through remembered disaster, but no house burns in this episode because of the online rumour. Across the long novel, an image from one material field moves into another. Recognising that figurative transfer is more illuminating than treating two different kinds of event as identical.

Forming a Group: From Warning to a New Institution

Nīraj organises village youths into a small group to examine dubious messages. Anjali had taught people to operate phones in [−42]; now the younger group shares a method of reading information critically. The novel suggests the development of a social capacity beyond merely using the machine. The number of members, meeting place, and particular steps

of verification are not given, however. Individual anxiety becomes collective instruction, while the everyday complications of the new organisation remain unknown.

Restoring Narrative Authority: The Village Reads Its Own News

The outsider in [−57] wrote the village's story through an alien classification; Vibhā requested official papers in [−40]; Nīraj now subjects digitally transmitted reports to questioning. Together these episodes show that the village rejects neither writing nor visual media themselves, but challenges monopoly over their meaning. Access to information, critical reading, and collective questioning become interlinked. One further question remains: could giving the youth group final authority to judge messages create a new concentration of power? The prose does not explore that possibility.

Burhbā's Balance: Fear Alongside Usefulness

Burhbā does not demand that the internet be discarded. He first recognises its new power and then advises caution. The ethical structure recalls earlier discussions of electricity, computers, and mobile phones. The repetition supplies a consistent communal value, but it also brings an artistic risk: every novel device might receive the same advice to be alert, examine, and preserve names. Whether familiar warnings can meet more sophisticated future deception becomes the question prepared for in [−36].

Mechanical Percentages and the Actual Sequence of Events

The meaningful sequence comprises the spread of smartphones; general description of multiple new risks; Nīraj's question; Burhbā's answer; circulation of a false report; the verification group's rebuttal; and the establishment of an enduring group. Repeated injunctions to "ask" and "examine" in the song are ethical repetitions, not additional incidents. Without this distinction, the chapter's apparent density of action can be misrepresented by the frequency of action words or song lines.

The Defeat of Misinformation: The Limit of a Successful Scene

Nīraj's group demonstrates that the particular report is false and warns the village. This successful response presents a possibility of communal self-defence. It does not describe what happens later to the sender, what injury the rumour caused, whether its influence persisted, or whether the police intervened. The conclusion that the village is now safe from every falsehood would therefore be unwarranted. The episode illustrates a skill through one event, not a permanent victory over digital deception.

Overall Judgement: A Story of Questioning Against Glitter

The chapter's central achievement is linking the problem of digital information to the village's older narrative question about what is seen and what it means. Nīraj's group opens a constructive possibility for the future. Its limits are an unnamed false message, a compressed account of verification, and another iteration of Burhbā's established counselling style. Felt anxiety and small-scale communal teaching provide a realistic basis, but the full machinery of an unseen antagonist on the screen is not disclosed. This incompleteness gives particular weight to the following two chapters.

The Primary Text and the Next Story

The analysis rests on the "Glitter and Web" song, the spread of smartphones, the Nīraj–Burhbā exchange, the anonymous false report, and the establishment of the checking group in original [–38]. The text does not provide the subject of the false news, the sender's country, the technical stages of checking it, or a specific crime previously committed against a child or young woman. In [–37], that general risk becomes the personal crisis of a young woman receiving threats.

Critical Section 64 | Original Chapter −37 — The Screen's First Shadow

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

From General Risk to Particular Suffering: The Narrative Descends

Chapter [−38] described unwanted online approaches to children and young women as a general risk; [−37] turns that risk into the particular case of a stranger using a girl's photograph to threaten her. The shift is narratively necessary. The danger of information now concerns not merely a community's access to accurate news, but an individual's shame, fear, and social isolation. The narrator begins with the wider spread of Facebook and WhatsApp, yet the decisive sequence involves Sapnā, Burhbā, and the transformation of a threatened young woman's private experience into speech before others.

"Shadow" as Metaphor: An Unnamed Agent Behind the Technological Screen

The proverb juxtaposes a glowing face on the screen with darkness around the identity behind it. The plenitude of images does not establish who uses them to threaten others. "Shadow" personifies concealed fear; no new literal ghost is born in the village. The narrator transfers an older ghost-image associated with the Channā grove to a hidden tormentor using a screen. This change of meaning lets the magical world of the novel furnish language for modern violations of privacy, without confusing supernatural agency with the real human act of harassment.

The Medium's Benefits Remain in the Opening

Before describing harm, the story mentions how distant relatives become reachable, old friends meet again, and news of happiness or sorrow travels at once. Without this recognition the chapter would be simply an attack on technology. Yet those benefits are presented as a collective opening summary rather than separately developed scenes. Dramatic space is given primarily to the harassment. The uneven allocation of narrative time gives the reader a sense of the medium's two-sided character while making the immediate ethical urgency of suffering more pronounced.

"A Girl from the Village": The Victim's Anonymity

Sapnā tells Burhbā that an unknown person is threatening a girl after obtaining her photograph. The narrator does not provide the girl's name. This anonymity can be read as protective, although that purpose is not

explicitly stated. By making her representative of a broader vulnerability, the narrative withholds an individual life history. There is a striking tension in a novel committed to preserving names: the threatened person's name is unavailable to the reader. Her narrative function is clear, while her distinct identity remains largely unspoken.

A Threat Using a Photograph: The Exact Limits of What Happened

The dialogue establishes that a photograph was used to threaten the young woman, but does not say what kind of image it was, how it was acquired, whether it was published, whether money was demanded, or whether it was altered. It would be contrary to the original to invent distribution of the image, sexually explicit editing, a proven particular sexual offence, or payment of a ransom. The central narrated act is the creation of fear through attempted control over a private image. The story touches a broad category of harassment while withholding the details of the particular offence.

Sapnā as a Narrative Intermediary

Nīraj's daughter Sapnā carries the young woman's situation into dialogue with Burhbā. At first the affected girl does not approach him in her own voice; Sapnā asks the question. The distribution of voices matters: the tormentor remains invisible; the girl is initially reported rather than heard; Sapnā enquires; Burhbā advises. Sapnā is therefore an active female organiser, though the girl's direct voice is delayed until the concluding night assembly. The delay makes speaking openly for the first time a genuine change in narrative state.

Burhbā's Trembling Voice: The Vulnerability of the Long-Lived Guardian

Burhbā admits that he does not fully understand this new kind of injustice. The admission is important from a witness who holds the memories of many generations. In several earlier sections his answer had the force of a final maxim; here his limits of knowledge become explicit. His "trembling voice" gives him an emotional presence. The proposed response nonetheless returns to older social resources: public recognition, resistance, and support. The text gives a small example of their possible effectiveness, not an exhaustive plan of digital protection.

Relocating Shame: The Discursive Places of Offender and Victim

The chief reversal in "Light and Shame" is the assertion that shame belongs to the tormentor, not the victim. Burhbā recognises that the offender depends on the girl's silence. Such language removes the girl from the centre of blame. But telling someone to "speak openly" cannot be

assumed to be the sole answer in every situation; the chapter does not investigate the risks to privacy and safety that disclosure might involve. Its moral support is meaningful without becoming a universally sufficient solution to all forms of harassment.

Two Meanings of Silence: Isolation Through Fear and Safety

Here silence is made a consequence of fear and a source of advantage to the offender. Yet in the Emergency chapter [−50], women had preserved their justice assembly through secret quietness and whispering. The narrative functions of the two silences oppose one another: in the earlier case quiet protects an institution against external repression; here it can protect a wrongdoer from challenge. The novel thus allows silence to be read neither as a universal virtue nor as a universal fault, although Burhbā's present speech does not elaborate the whole distinction.

The First Digital Night Assembly: An Institution Changes Form

Sapnā turns the older women's night assembly into a "digital night assembly." In [−66] it heard domestic grievances; in [−60] it organised collective labour against fire; in [−50] it preserved justice meetings under restrictions; now it addresses harassment mediated by screens. This repeated adaptation is a notable feat of long-form narrative construction: an institution gains fresh capacities when historical dangers change. Yet the text does not technically specify whether "digital" means an online meeting or an in-person assembly concerned with digital problems. Its established meaning is the old institution acting on a new issue.

The Victim's First Open Statement: The Central Event

At the night assembly, the young woman speaks openly about her experience "for the first time." The narrative state changes: a second-hand report becomes direct testimony, and isolated fear acquires communal listeners. Her entire statement, however, is not quoted. The narrator summarises it as her having "told her story." There is thus a distinction between granting her a moral presence as a speaking person and reproducing the individual texture of her actual words. The novel shows that her voice returns without giving the reader that voice in full.

Ten or Twenty Women Beside Her: The Literary Function of Number

The story says that "ten or twenty" women stand with the young woman. The approximate number makes shared support visible; it is not a statistical membership roll. On one side is an invisible tormentor against a single threatened person; on the other, that person stands within a visible group. The altered configuration provides emotional resolution. The other women's names, deliberations, disagreements, and specific protective

actions are not detailed. The collective body becomes a protagonist without fully differentiated individual voices.

The Threat "Weakens": A Careful Reading of the Outcome

After the women stand together, the invisible threat "suddenly weakens," and a smile returns to the girl's face. "Weakens" does not establish that the perpetrator was arrested, the image deleted, or the offence conclusively ended. The limited verb records a first relief rather than a definitive judicial resolution. Her smile is an emotional accomplishment, not a full evidentiary record of remedy. Criticism should acknowledge exactly as much improvement as the prose shows, neither denying the support nor inventing a final outcome.

Sharing the Burden of Listening: The Narrative Distribution of Pain

The description that the assembly joins in carrying the burden she had borne alone gives sympathy a material metaphor. Support is not simply a speech: the addition of listeners changes the victim's social situation. The movement from hidden harassment to communal encounter carries the reader from solitary fear towards shared protection. What the narrative does not stage is the bringing of the offender into a process of accountability. Sharing a burden cannot be treated as identical to judicial redress.

Another Form of the "Ghost": Magical Language and an Actual Response

The story calls the concealed digital oppressor a "new ghost." Yet protection comes from the women standing publicly with the girl and from Sapnā's organising, not from Burhbā supernaturally destroying a tormentor. Magical comparison and realistic collective action coexist. The novel's long tradition of memories and ghosts lends language to a digital shadow, while human beings perform the work of helping. Holding these two levels together is a significant achievement of its narrative technique.

Openness and Privacy: An Unanswered Narrative Difficulty

Burhbā's injunction to speak and stand together breaks the isolation of the victim. Yet public disclosure in digital harassment may itself spread identification, images, or personal details further. The chapter does not discuss that possibility. Rather than inventing a new event, criticism can ask how much publicity the girl herself consented to and what precautions were available. The text does not answer. The silence leaves a potential tension between the ethics of a new forum for justice and the protection of personal relationships and privacy.

Stylistic Foreclosure: The Song Gives the Solution First

The song announces in advance that collective speech will disperse the darkness. The prose stages the same answer. Consequently, the outcome is not wholly unforeseen by the reader; the value lies in how it is reached. The initial threat, Sapnā's dialogue with Burhbā, the girl's statement, and the women's support constitute four successive acts performing the song's moral proposition. Dramatic uncertainty is limited, whereas the feeling of relief is heightened.

Overall Evaluation: The Unnamed Victim Recovers Speech

The chapter's main strength is making the private fear of an unnamed young woman a subject of communal hearing. Sapnā's action brings an established women's institution into the digital world. Its limitations are the absence or brevity of the victim's actual statement, the offender's identification, accountability, and procedures of digital protection. Restoring the proper place of shame is ethically compelling, but the formation of an institution is not equivalent to every form of justice being done. The focus here is the value of social assistance.

Source Limits and the Next Section

The evidence is the song "Light and Shame," the arrival of Facebook and WhatsApp, the threat reported by Sapnā, Burhbā's trembling response, the girl's first open statement, and the digital night assembly. No name for the girl or offender, public dissemination of the photograph, or police action appears in the source. In [–36], the danger of unseen digital power broadens from protection of personal images to fraudulent employment offers and the theft of savings.

Critical Section 65 | Original Chapter −36 — The First Footfall of the Unseen Fraudster

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

The Structural Meaning of "First Footfall"

The title speaks of a "first footfall," although the prose describes a serious event in which a young man loses his entire savings. A footfall does not mean that harm is only half-complete; it signals the approach of a more complex world of future offences. The present fraud therefore does more than finish a local incident: it introduces a new kind of adversary into the narrative world. In [−38] false news was checked and disproved; in [−37] the threatened young woman gained communal support. In [−36] the crime has already succeeded. The apparently easy progression of ethical victories is interrupted.

The Promise of a Job: Hope as the Gateway to Risk

The fraud begins with the young man's wish to find employment. After the accounts of metropolitan jobs in [−41] and the right to employment in [−39], the prospect of "good work" itself becomes an instrument of deception. The young man's exact financial circumstances are not described, but losing his entire accumulated savings clearly conveys the magnitude of the disaster. The unseen fraudster uses the language of hope rather than merely showing digital cleverness. Wanting employment is not the fault: a fraudulent offer adopts the credible surface of that desire. The victim's name, age, and dependants are not given.

Website, Office Photograph, Official's Voice: A Manufactured Appearance of Credibility

Three media are listed: a website, a photograph of an office, and an official-sounding voice. Together they constitute the dramatic appearance of a genuine company. The fraudster's own body remains unseen, but the constructed visual and auditory signs are supplied. The young man's trust is focalised through the possibility that what he saw and heard seemed to indicate a legitimate institution. There is no mention of deepfakes, a specifically forged document, or synthesised voice technology. Importing any such technical device into the episode would be unsupported.

Vanishing in One Night: The Cruel Compression of Narrative Time

Once the young man has sent his money, the company, website, and voice vanish within a night. Savings assembled through an unknown but

prolonged period of effort are destroyed in a single night's narration. This contrast makes the violence of the deception felt: the time taken to construct credible appearances remains obscure, while the disappearance of all contact is abrupt. The precise hour at which the website closed, the number of attempted calls, and the first moment of suspicion are not dramatised. The prose privileges the suddenness of the result over a minute-by-minute reconstruction.

The Fraudster's Anonymity and the Young Man's Anonymity

The story expressly does not know who the real fraudster was or where the person was located. That uncertainty is part of the offence's narrative form. The deceived young man is also unnamed. The two absences have different meanings: the criminal's unknown identity produces the mystery, while the victim's lack of a name marks a limit of individual representation. In a novel devoted to saving names, the loss extends symbolically beyond money towards social identity. But this remains an interpretive possibility: the text does not narrate anyone literally erasing the victim's actual name.

A Police Complaint: Available Procedure and Uncertain Remedy

The prose says that a report is registered with the police. This takes the communal response into the domain of legal institutions. The case number, investigative steps, recovery of funds, and arrest of an accused person are all absent. The question "How does one catch someone who cannot even be seen?" remains unresolved. A critical translation must neither declare that the police conclusively failed nor invent the arrest of a criminal abroad. What the story establishes after the complaint is continuing uncertainty.

"Neither Face nor Address": Constructing an Invisible Opponent

Earlier adversaries—kings, landlords, soldiers, and visiting authors—were mostly visible or named. Here the opponent's deeds are evident but the face of the person responsible is missing. Conflict moves from confronting a rival in the square to protecting a community against an unseen network. The absence of an identifiable offender itself becomes a source of fear. Yet the text does not determine whether a single person or a group operated the deception. The metaphor of a "new crocodile" cannot substitute for that missing concrete identification.

Old Crocodile and New Crocodile: The Journey of an Image from Water to Wires

The song "Unseen Crocodile" says that the old crocodile could be seen in water, while the new one hides among wires. The older world of the Jorī pond—its crocodile, rituals, fear, gifts, and the preservation of names—is

transferred into a metaphor for digital fraud. The distance between the visible waterscape and the abstract network forms an aesthetic achievement of the novel's historical sweep. Still, the song's claim that the old crocodile was entirely visible does not necessarily describe every uncanny incident in the earlier story. The contrast is sharpened for poetic purposes.

"Not Offerings, but Trust": The Changed Object of the Lure

Burhbā says that the new crocodile seeks not offerings but trust, which it steals. An old pattern of ritual exchange is displaced by the modern exploitation of belief. The line conveys the offence's ethical nature: confidence is elicited to obtain economic benefit. The young man sends money because he trusts the presented company. That does not make every older offering secure or establish that all future frauds function identically. The analogy operates symbolically through a difference in what the two figures are said to take.

Sapnā Again as Intermediary: From Personal Loss to a Question Under the Peepal

After [–37], Sapnā again brings a crisis to Burhbā. This time her concern is not threats against a young woman's image but a young man's experience of fraud. The recurrence strengthens her character as a bearer of communal information and an organiser of responses. The injured young man does not, however, speak to Burhbā directly. His words are absent from the dialogue, absorbed into the narrator's swift summary and Sapnā's worried question. Attention shifts to Burhbā's astonishment and counsel, leaving the victim's subsequent livelihood marginal.

Burhbā's Inability: The Real Limit of Long Memory

Burhbā admits that he does not know how his old knowledge can fight this new crocodile. This is a significant crisis of character. Previously he could propose measures drawing upon memories of ponds, groves, registers, or women's assemblies; here the invisible structure of the offence exceeds his familiar resources. The moment unsettles his image as a provider of every solution. Ultimately he returns to the older ethical response of public awareness, so uncertainty and counsel coexist in a newly tense relationship.

The Duty of Remembrance Against Concealed Crime

Burhbā pledges that if this new crocodile consumes someone's name, he will protect that name in memory. Remembrance here does not become a technical way to stop fraud; it is an ethical promise against forgetting the injured person's existence. The lost money has not returned and the

offender has not been identified. Yet the promise prevents the episode from ending in total moral emptiness. Whether remembrance alone can provide economic justice remains an open question. By recognising the limits of Burhbā's knowledge, the narrative leaves room to distinguish honouring victims from recovering their losses.

An Awareness Campaign: From Individual Injury to the Community

Sapnā begins warning every family about the risks of online offers. This is the episode's final positive social action. In [–38], Nīraj's group learned to scrutinise information; in [–37], the digital night assembly gave a threatened girl support; now Sapnā provides household-by-household warnings against fraud. The responses are related but not interchangeable: scrutiny, support, and prevention each have distinct narrative functions. The text does not claim that no further fraudulent offer ever succeeds following this campaign.

"Trust the Eye, Not Paper": The Proverb's Internal Irony

The proverb urges belief in the eye rather than paper, while the actual deception operates through visible signs: a website and an office photograph. The apparent inconsistency matters. The song later warns against trusting glitter blindly, and Burhbā also urges caution. Read literally, the opening praise of eyesight is contradicted by the prose's demonstration that the eye may be deceived. It may instead signify an exhortation to alert examination, but the wording remains ambiguous enough to register as a literary tension.

The Instability of Visual Proof: Return of the Shell-and-Silver Line

A fabricated office image, website, and voice create the appearance of a genuine business. The problem of shell and silver in [–100]—that the interpretation of what is seen may differ from the object—reappears in digital commerce. The difference is substantial. The early episode unfolded as an extended dramatic debate about error, whereas here the consequence is economic and practical. Symbolic continuity is strong, but this chapter gives no complete technical reconstruction of the fictitious company. Fear arises from the ambiguity of apparently credible signs.

The Song's Moral Verdict and the Prose's Unfinished Outcome

The song teaches that those who question and test an offer can avoid the trap. The prose ends with a real young man deceived, a complaint filed, and a warning campaign established. Neither the recovery of money, the capture of the offender, nor the restoration of the victim's confidence is confirmed. The song thus expresses a rule for conduct to come, not a

complete summary of events already concluded. The prose's incompleteness keeps the future of digital crime open within the novel.

Pressure from the Unseen Adversary: Foreshadowing the Next Chapter

Sapnā's final understanding is that the next stage may be more complex and dangerous. This is a future-oriented narrative signal, not evidence of additional crimes already carried out in this episode. The antagonist expands in significance from one young man's loss towards a wider and unfamiliar field of digital threats. This foreshadowing supplies the title's full meaning: the "first footfall" marks the threshold of a new narrative phase rather than a complete ending. Readers accept an expectation of greater danger without yet knowing its particular form.

Overall Judgement: First Failure, Incomplete Remedy

The chapter's chief achievement is the tangible sequence from a deceptively credible website to the loss of an entire store of savings. After two preceding episodes of relatively successful communal resistance, this injury brings genuine instability into the narrative. Burhbā's acknowledgment of limited knowledge gives his character additional credibility. The limits are the absence of the victim's fuller experience, details of the police investigation, the amount lost, and the offender's identity. Warning others is a social response, not complete judicial or financial restitution.

Textual Basis, Limits and the Next Stage

This analysis is grounded in the song "Unseen Crocodile," the false job offer, the website–photograph–voice combination, the company's disappearance in one night, the police complaint, Sapnā's question, Burhbā's uncertainty, and the household awareness campaign in original [–36]. The offender's geographical location, the sum of money, any refund, and any arrest are unknown. The next chapter, [–35], "The Market for Bodies Opens," takes the questions of digital deception and labour migration towards another, potentially more bodily form of violence. Its actual events require separate reading of the original text rather than anticipation being treated as fact.

Critical Section 66 | Original Chapter −35 — The Market for Bodies Opens

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

A Narrative Turn from Fraud to a Crisis of the Human Body

Chapter [−36] presented a fraudulent online company that took a young villager's savings and vanished. In [−35], intermediaries enticing young people with employment take some of them abroad, from where reports arrive of confiscated passports and enforced labour. The change is not merely an increase in the scale of loss: the very object of crisis has altered. Previously the chief injury was financial; now bodily freedom of movement, the right to labour, and contact with one's family are threatened. The narrator makes this progression explicit through the contrast between what happened earlier and what is happening now. Yet the prose does not establish that the perpetrators of the first fraud and the agents involved here belong to the same organisation.

The "Body" in the Opening Proverb: The Poetics of Commodification

The proverb about the place "where bodies are sold" condenses an alarming social condition into the image of a human being turned into merchandise. The prose reports coercive work abroad and the confiscation of passports; it does not depict an open auction, a price list, a named purchaser, or the literal sale of a body. Accordingly, the "market" chiefly figures the commodification of human freedom and the coercive control of labour. Reading the image as a literally narrated transaction would obscure the prose's specific acts of oppression: the seizure of documents and the silencing of voices. The song's encompassing terror and the narrative's more limited evidence must remain distinct.

From Sapnā to Rājīv: A Sequence of Crises Within a Genealogical Succession

The first prose sentence reports that responsibility for the name-ritual passes from Sapnā to her son Rājīv. This is the briefest possible announcement of generational transition, immediately followed by the rise in deceptive offers of overseas employment. In the previous chapter Sapnā had begun warning households about cyber-fraud; Rājīv turns that vigilance towards the protection of human bodies. The former character withdraws not through a fully developed life-history but through the introduction of her successor. Across the trilogy, such genealogical threads

bridge long temporal intervals between events, although Rājīv's inner life here emerges almost entirely in reaction to the immediate crisis.

News in "Fragments": Incomplete Information as Narrative Form

News that young migrants have had passports taken away and are being compelled to work reaches the village "in fragments". That phrase is crucial. Rather than allowing villagers or readers to see the overseas location directly, the narrator chooses a structure of broken and delayed reports. The foreign workplace, the employer's actual speech, an account of withheld wages, and attempts at escape remain outside the narrated scenes. This lack of information is itself part of the village's condition. Receiving news is not equivalent to witnessing an event. Although the novel extends a village-centred story towards the overseas lives of its people, it gains a wider sense of danger at the cost of a relative scarcity of direct experience.

The Missing Son: The Long Duration of Absence in One Household

One village household has received no news for years of a son who went abroad. Rather than constructing a named victim's biography, the text makes the duration of his absence central. "For years" expands narrative time without recounting the events of each successive year. Whether he has died, is detained, has voluntarily lost contact, or might return remains unsettled. A critical reading cannot declare him dead or imprisoned in some definite location without exceeding the text. The force of this episode lies precisely in its lack of an answer.

The Waiting Mother: A Restricted Centre of Focalisation

The mother's eyes turning towards the road every evening turn fragmentary reports from a far-off country into an image of domestic endurance. The narrator does not bring the unseen son directly before the reader; absence is experienced through his mother's waiting. "Every evening" is an iterative temporal construction, making a single day's anguish the recurring rule of many years. The mother receives neither a name nor an autonomous stretch of dialogue. Although she is the emotional centre, much of the explicit right to speak remains with Rājīv and Burhbā. The allocation of feeling and speech is therefore uneven.

The Seizure of Passports: A Document Becomes an Instrument of Bodily Confinement

The confiscation of passports is the decisive action because such a document formally mediates the migrant's identity and freedom of movement abroad. In earlier critical sections, registers, official records, and notebooks functioned as objects preserving memory. Here the removal of a document becomes a device for confining a person. The reversal in the

narrative role of paper deserves attention. The text does not specify the relevant national office, law, intermediary, or the exact sequence through which the passports were taken. The object's narrative force is clear, while the institutional machinery remains compressed.

The Foreign Country Seen from the Village: An Unshown Stage

The narrative concentrates on Rājīv's experience in the village, information received from afar, and the conversation beneath the peepal. Although the crisis originates overseas, that place is not developed into a directly represented dramatic setting. Geographic distance thus becomes a limit on the reader's knowledge. We do not see the internal organisation of the agents, the victims' daily work, or the practical possibilities of rescue. The village-centred standpoint permits the novel to register a crisis beyond its boundaries; it also leaves direct experience of migrant suffering comparatively sparse.

Remembering the Indenture Narrative: Comparison, Not Equivalence

Rājīv compares the current danger to the older history of indentured migration and remarks that at least contracts and dates existed in that earlier system. This is a character's comparison, not an impartial narratorial judgement that all historical indentured labour was relatively safe. The chapter brings a new trap in overseas employment into contact with the long memory of labour migration that extends across the novel. The comparison activates the ethical weight of earlier suffering, but it must not erase the different mechanisms of exploitation in the two historical periods. The intertextual act is one of recollection, not a claim of complete identity.

Burhbā's "New Crocodile": The Continuing Expansion of a Metaphor

The "new crocodile" that had inhabited wires and screens in [–36] now becomes an image of a predator consuming bodily liberty. Burhbā extends the apprehension from digital fraud towards human trafficking and coercive labour. No literal crocodile is depicted arriving in an overseas factory. Instead, the crocodile becomes a recurring figurative designation for shifting forms of predatory social power. Its strength lies in connecting the novel's original water-borne fear to the modern labour market. Its possible limitation is the reduction of distinct crimes, institutions, and experiences of pain to a single monstrous image.

A Changed Meaning of "Saving Names": From Remembrance of the Dead to Protection of the Living

Burhbā says that preserving names is no longer simply a work of memory; it has become a work of life. This compact formulation redirects the trilogy's long-standing commitment. Where the keeping of the dead person's name was once an act of subsequent remembrance, the immediate concern now is to protect the identity of living young people, verify offers of employment, and prevent their relationships from being severed. The original story, however, does not show the missing son being located and brought home. The aim has changed from preserving memory to protecting life, but the achievement of an actual rescue is not yet narrated. The distance between accomplishment and aspiration must remain visible.

The Order of Questions: A New Action for the Protagonist in Crisis

Burhbā proposes a sequence of questions about prospective jobs: Who is calling? Which company is involved? What kind of papers have been provided? Who offers a guarantee? Narratively, these are not merely general admonitions against credulity; they provide an order of possible actions for subsequent episodes. Rājīv begins teaching young people to investigate such offers. No independent scene shows him examining one particular offer and stopping an actual departure. The beginning of instruction is an established event here; the prevention of every later deception remains an unverified future possibility.

Rājīv's School: The Institutional Transformation of Knowledge

Towards the end, Rājīv begins teaching young people how to examine the documents and agents involved in foreign employment. The established educational pattern of the Coconut-Leaf School gains a new purpose: earlier, learning to read letters; now, learning to read risk. Education becomes a procedure for communal protection rather than merely an extension of formal curriculum. The narrator supplies neither individual classroom scenes, named pupils, a training period, nor an eventual examination. The institution's formation is compressed into a single summary statement. Such compression advances the narrative rapidly, although it does not dramatise the pupils' transformation in detail.

The Song's "Captive Net" and the Prose's Missing-Person Report

The song "A Mother's Warning" offers a vivid image of sons and daughters caught in a distant net of captivity. The prose, however, provides fragmentary reports that some migrants have had their passports seized and are forced into labour; it does not establish the final condition of the one missing son. The song's plural image of danger must not become a

definite outcome for that particular young man. The song constructs collective compassion and vigilance; the prose offers limited available information. Maintaining the difference does not minimise the actual suffering. It makes the unresolved quality of that suffering legible.

Caste, Class, and Gender: The Generalisation of "Village Youths"

The text does not provide individual caste identities or detailed economic circumstances for the young people deceived by employment offers. Rather than giving a distinctly named poor household, it speaks of a household; the mother waiting for her son supplies the visual image. No specific experience of a female migrant taken by an agent is narrated, although the song refers to both sons and daughters. Consequently, different groups' distinct risks and voices remain subdued within the ambition of comprehensive communal protection. Filling this gap with invented victims would be a violation of the source; identifying the form of the omission is part of literary evaluation.

Narrative Pace: Long-Lasting Loss, Rapid Response

A few sentences cover the rise of the agents, overseas departures, confiscated passports, and the years of waiting in one household. By contrast, Rājīv and Burhbā's dialogue beneath the peepal receives comparatively sustained space. The actual duration of grief and its narrated duration stand in inverse proportion. Rules for caution are articulated at length, whereas no concrete rescue has yet taken place. The structure increases the force of the warning but abbreviates the lived conditions of the victims. That selection determines the narrative's ethical centre.

The Response to Fear Is Not Merely "Unity": Institutional Distance

Earlier disaster chapters showed people collectively building embankments, evacuating those in danger, or distributing grain. Here the crisis lies thousands of miles away, amid the control of documents and broken channels of communication. The village can act collectively by issuing warnings, but it has no immediate physical command over the foreign scene. Through Burhbā's advice to ask and verify questions, the novel tries to negotiate that imbalance. The complexity of distance distinguishes this chapter from a simple repetition of the community's victorious response to an earlier flood.

"The Vigilant Were Saved": The Song's Unproved Generalisation

The final stanza draws an almost inevitable connection between advance vigilance and safety. The prose complicates this confidence with a family waiting for a missing young man, a lack of reliable information, and difficulties of rescue. It supplies no complete chain showing that every

victim was deceived because he failed to ask questions, or that everyone who asked was necessarily safe. The song's maxim is a collective warning; it must never be used to assign blame to victims or to claim their suffering resulted from a failure of intelligence.

Overall Assessment: Unseen Labouring Bodies and a Visible Mother

The chapter's strength lies in its progression from financial fraud to human confinement, the mother's protracted waiting, and the transformation of name-preservation into a responsibility towards living people. Rājīv's teaching provides a useful narrative action through which communal responsibility is expressed. Its major limitations are the absence of victims' direct voices, overseas scenes, and outcomes of justice or rescue. The narrator sketches the ethical dimensions of the crisis without recounting the entire lives of those harmed. That incompleteness remains an important question for subsequent characters.

Source Basis and the Next Connection

This reading is based on the opening proverb and the song "A Mother's Warning" in Chapter [−35], Rājīv's genealogical entrance, reports concerning the migrants, the unnamed waiting mother, the dialogue between Rājīv and Burhbā, and the final summary of the cautionary school. No named foreign factory, victim's death, or successful liberation is described. The next chapter [−34] shifts from the violent present to the longer possibilities of the future through the birth of a child and Burhbā's earlier vision.

Critical Section 67 | Original Chapter −34 — Ujjwal's Dream

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From a Violent Present to a Birth: A Pause in Narrative Rhythm

Chapter [−35] ended with the frightening image of a son missing abroad and a mother waiting for him. Chapter [−34] begins with a child's birth in a poor family and a sohar, the customary birth song. On the level of external events this is a movement from crisis to celebration. Yet Burhbā's unexpected anxiety plants the possibility of a future disaster inside the festivities. The opportunity to introduce a new personal name thus becomes an instrument of anticipation. The chapter offers a respite without extinguishing the reader's unease: the light of birth and the darkness of a possible calamity inhabit the same narrative place.

Ujjwal's Name: Brightness of Meaning, Darkness of Possible Events

The newborn is named Ujjwal Jha. The brightness suggested by the name and Burhbā's apprehension of a young man submerged in a screen form an oppositional structure. The story does not establish that the name itself determines the boy's luminous or dark destiny. It is a memorable sign preparing readers to recognise this person when he returns in later chapters. By pronouncing his name the narrator marks him as a character for the future, but the name does not itself constitute the history of his life.

A Poor Family in One Sentence: The Limits of Social Background

The original calls Ujjwal's household “a poor family of the village”. This detail establishes economic circumstance as a potential context for the anxiety to come. It does not identify the home, income, parental occupations, indebtedness, or specific social status. The surname “Jha” must not be used to invent an individual account of caste or class conditions. The narrative indicates poverty but does not describe it in detail. A connection with a possible future financial crisis may occur to the reader, but no actual loan is contracted in this chapter.

A Communal Birth Ritual and Private Unease Beneath the Peepal

Inside the household the birth song is sung, jaggery distributed, and joy shared. At the very same time Burhbā becomes disturbed beneath the peepal. The opposition is the principal narrative device: the village celebrates the present birth while Burhbā perceives in it an image of a

possible future crisis. The statement that nobody has previously seen him so agitated immediately marks his behaviour as unusual. The bystanders' responses are not developed into independent dialogue, however; Dīpālī's question supplies the main channel through which that unease enters the narrative.

Burhbā's Earlier Glimpse: Foreshadowing, Not a Complete Future Narrative

Burhbā says that many years previously he glimpsed a youth drowning "not in a river, but in a screen". The glimpse is not a loan-related accident verified in the narrative present; it is his account of an earlier perception. "Lost money, interest, threats" constitute three signals of a possible impending crisis, without identifying when, how, or through whose actions these things will occur. The uncertainty tempts readers to fill in the image for themselves. Critical precision requires keeping projected events separate from completed ones.

"Not in the River, but in the Screen": A Transformation of the Trilogy's Central Image

The older image of drowning in a river belongs to the novel's tradition of water-burial. Here "drowning in a screen" figures entanglement in digital finance, psychological distress, and threats. The physical action of water covering a body does not occur. Technology supplies a new visual language for an inherited fear of death. Through the image the long trilogy translates its water-centred theme into a contemporary world of money and numbers; sameness of metaphor is not sameness of material result.

Burhbā's Awareness of the Limits of His Vision

Burhbā explicitly says he does not know how the dream will become true, or whether he can save Ujjwal. His account of a previous glimpse therefore contains a declaration of limited knowledge. The long-lived witness is not made into an all-powerful controller of the future, but a keeper of memory troubled by possibility. His promise, "I am keeping his name from today," is a commitment to remember in the present, not an act which visibly averts a later disaster. The text consequently avoids presenting a straightforward command of fate.

Dīpālī's Question: Making Fear Narratable

Rājīv's daughter Dīpālī asks why Burhbā is so disturbed. Her question opens a passage through which concealed information about the future can reach the reader. Without it his exceptional behaviour might remain a mystery; the question converts anxiety into a narrated account. Dīpālī, however, has not herself witnessed the future glimpse. She hears Burhbā describing it.

The single originating source of that apprehension is thus his earlier experience, not a second independent scene or document. Dīpālī's response is an expression of trust.

Unspoken Watching: Communal Affection or Surveillance?

The village begins to keep an eye on Ujjwal "without saying anything". At his first school day, first bathing in the pond, and first departure from the village, someone's watchful gaze accompanies him. Such recurrence embodies communal care, but the child is unaware of the supervision. The boundary between protective solidarity and unwanted observation opens here. The narrator colours the watching as benevolent; its meaning is not examined through Ujjwal's own point of view. Critical attention should recognise that ambiguity as an effect of narrative perspective.

Three Events of Childhood: A Life Compressed into Selected Signs

The narrative mentions Ujjwal's first school entry, his first swim or bathing in the pond, and his first journey out of the village together. This is not a year-by-year biography but a list of selected markers of growth. They allow the reader to feel childhood passing without giving every event its own date, companions, or dialogue. The temporal compression keeps the chapter's principal energy focused less on the child's present life than on concern for his future. Story time lengthens as the amount of narrated time remains slight.

The Child's Ignorance and the Reader's Additional Knowledge

Ujjwal grows and plays in the village without knowing about the "unspoken watch" placed upon him. The reader, Dīpālī, and Burhbā know something of the ominous anticipation; the child does not. The unequal distribution of information creates dramatic irony. His ordinary games take on the background of an indeterminate threat. Yet the reader's informational privilege is itself partial, for the glimpse's outcome remains unknown. Some characters know more than others, but none possesses the complete answer.

Dīpālī's Notebook: A Mysterious Mark in an Ordinary Register

In the regular birth register Dīpālī places "an additional mark" beside Ujjwal's name. The shape, written explanation, and future method of using the mark are not given. The object functions as a store of anticipation for later narrative developments. A public record of birth and a private suspicion coexist on the same page. The unexplained sign prepares the reader for a future return, but offers no justification for constructing a fully imagined secret plan.

The Birth Song's Apparently Prophetic Voice

The song "Dream and Roots" joins the child's future with communal reassurance: he will not be alone in darkness, and a dream joined to its roots will flower. Burhbā's uncertainty remains unaltered in the prose: he does not yet know whether he can protect the child. The song's future tense is an emotional pledge, not a definite outcome in the story. Conflating them would saddle the characters with an impossible guarantee. The song speaks in the community's language of hope; the prose retains the private language of unexpressed fear.

"The Village Will Keep Watch": The Limits of the Collective Protagonist

The song calls the village the newborn's guardian. The prose partly embodies the declaration through the eyes of unnamed observers. It narrates no concrete attempt to prevent a mistaken financial decision, a dangerous proposal, or another crisis in the boy's later life. The achievement of care is restricted to the continuance of watchful identification; its eventual effectiveness has not been tested. "The village knew" and "the village saved him" are not equivalent statements.

Narrative Foresight and Self-Reference

Burhbā's earlier glimpse declares that the newborn may become a figure in the great future narrative. Such epic-scale foreshadowing gives readers reason to attend differently to later chapters. The text offers a story about prediction, however, not the already disclosed outcome of the whole book. Time is layered: a vision experienced many years earlier, the present of the birth, and the possibility of a catastrophe not yet encountered. This temporal construction sets the chapter apart from an ordinary birth account.

Emotional Proportion: Burhbā's Anxiety and the Infant's Silence

Ujjwal cannot speak at his birth, while the names and private hopes of his parents are also absent. Narrative weight falls on Burhbā's fear and Dīpālī's act of recording. The projection of a possible future therefore affects the reader before the newborn's independent character can take shape. This selection increases the child's prospective dramatic importance, but risks placing the ordinary life of an infant beneath the shadow of a predetermined task. Identifying that tension is not the same as declaring his final fate.

An Agitated Burhbā: A Human Moment in an Extraordinary Character

Villagers report never having seen Burhbā so anxious. Fear grants a sense of helplessness to a figure of apparently inexhaustible memory. He may see fragments of the future, yet remains unsure whether he can change an outcome. The contradiction allows him to share a recognisably human predicament with the reader: sensing danger in the life of someone who matters, without knowing how to prevent it. This emotional condition is among the chapter's most consequential narratological achievements.

Principal Critical Conclusion: A Present Contaminated by the Future

The chapter gives the light of a new birth a changed meaning through the threat suspended over it. Its crucial subtlety is that Ujjwal has not yet committed an offence, taken a loan, or become trapped in online gambling. His life still opens as a field of possibilities. Anxiety nonetheless enters childhood through the village's watch and Dīpālī's notebook. The chapter is strong in foreshadowing, temporal interweaving, and Burhbā's self-limitation; its weakness is the scant development of the child's own voice and his family's personal history. Anticipation drives the story but must not be mistaken for accomplished fact.

Source Boundaries and the Following Section

This discussion draws on the birth song, the naming of Ujjwal Jha, Burhbā's glimpse of "drowning in a screen", Dīpālī's question, the watching of Ujjwal during childhood, and the notebook bearing its additional mark. The dream's complete verification, the actual amount of any later debt, and the identity of any deceiver are not given. Chapter [—33] turns to Batuknath's moral journey, shaping another possible participant in the impending web of crises.

Critical Section 68 | Original Chapter −33 — The Shadow of the Lawyer's Coat

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A Character's Arc from Promising Student to Controversial Lawyer

The chapter first presents Batuknath as a talented student of the Coconut-Leaf School and a young lawyer who initially defends the poor. This beginning makes his subsequent moral deviation more acute. A figure who deceived his clients from the outset would not have the same story of decline. The narrator first establishes social expectation, then describes a gradual change of course under the allure of powerful clients, victories, money, and reputation. Yet there is no individual record of each case, single decisive date, or fully dramatised moment of choice: the arc is built primarily through a collective narratorial summary.

The Time of "Gradually": Decline Is Not a Single Event

Batuknath's transformation is not declared to be a betrayal committed in one instant. Expressions such as "gradually" and "one step after another" indicate an unspecified succession of repeated choices. Through that language readers understand not an isolated incident but the formation of a habitual manner of acting. The narrator compresses a long interval into a short account. The device is effective in suggesting how a change of professional ethics may occur, while leaving the social circumstances of individual compromises indistinct. Complexity is consequently left partly to the reader's inference.

A Clause of Law: What Changes Is Its Use

The same legal provision that was formerly deployed to protect the poor is later "turned" to the advantage of the powerful. The narrative does not offer the simple proposition that law is inherently corrupt: it shows the direction of its use changing. "Turning a clause" figures the power to manipulate legal language. Which clause, judicial order, judge, or precise case outcome is involved remains unstated. The legal particulars are therefore uncertain, but the character's self-interested redirection of language is intelligible.

Coat and Peepal: Two Contrasting Social Settings

The song opposes justice hidden beneath the shadow of a lawyer's "coat" to justice spoken in the village. In the prose, the coat signals Batuknath's professional authority and the peepal supplies the site of Dīpālī's moral

questioning. Yet the opposition must not become a blanket condemnation of city and court, for the lawyer had earlier defended poor clients within that very urban legal system. His initial integrity preserves a complexity that a formula such as "the city is always unjust and the village always just" would erase.

"Date After Date": The Return of an Older Motif of Delay

Dīpālī accuses Batuknath of repeatedly seeking adjournments in cases where poor people are on the opposing side. The phrase recalls the earlier Chapter [–68], "The Court's First Hearing Date", an echo Burhbā himself recognises. The long narrative is not merely repeating the judicial institution; it shows an old social defect reappearing through a new character. Batuknath, however, was not personally responsible for the original delay described in the previous episode. Historical recurrence and individual culpability must remain separate.

Dīpālī's Voice: Witness or Interpreter?

Dīpālī describes Batuknath's changed conduct as something like a "ghost of the courtroom". This is her troubled metaphorical assessment. The narrator reports both his early honesty and his later association with influential clients; "ghost" does not signify an actual supernatural change. The dialogue gives the ethical crisis an emotional vocabulary. Dīpālī's worry may be credible, but it does not provide direct access to the lawyer's entire inner consciousness.

Burhbā's Account of Origins: Rejecting Innate Evil

Burhbā says that Batuknath was not born bad. He points to three contributing forces: the system's slowness, temptation, and the taste of power. His formulation turns moral decline into a narrative of environment and habit rather than congenital wickedness. Yet his account remains one perspective on Batuknath, and the narrator does not balance it with the lawyer's sustained confession. The system cannot therefore be declared solely responsible for every choice. Structural tendencies and personal opportunism coexist within the story.

"Seed" and "Flower": What the Temporal Metaphor Accomplishes

In Burhbā's account, a "seed" of injustice is planted in one period and becomes a "flower" in someone's behaviour in another. The metaphor gives the generations of the long novel a compact image. Readers can connect the present lawyer's conduct with the history of older institutions, but the flower is not a biological law guaranteeing a predetermined moral outcome. If it were inevitable, the possibility that Batuknath could alter

course would vanish. The source preserves both the pressure of structures and a door still open to personal choice.

The Poor Widow's Arrival: From Group Summary to One Encounter

At first "the poor", "powerful clients", and "cases" are collective categories. Later a poor widow from the village comes before Batuknath in a dispute over her field. Her particular presence sharpens the ethical question. She comes from the village whose names he has known since childhood, and that old attachment stands directly before his professional evasions. The text does not name her, state the area of the field, set out the pleadings, or disclose a verdict. The episode is a device of awakened memory, not the narration of a just legal resolution.

"One Moment" of Light: The Instability of Interior Focalisation

When the widow stands before him, the "old village flashed" in Batuknath's eyes. He then returns to the language of legal clauses. This brief image is his most complex moment. The reader senses the revival of an older moral memory, but it is not strong enough to change the decision then and there. Instead of a full internal monologue the narrator offers a visual instant. The scene rejects the notion that he is a wholly fixed villain, while equally refusing an easy sentimental conclusion that he has immediately reformed.

The Widow's Legal Position: An Unanswered Question

The widow appears before Batuknath, but the prose does not say whether she is claimant or respondent, whether he represents her or an adversary, or how the land dispute ends. "Her field's case" is identified; its procedural relations remain obscure. The claim that Batuknath defeated her in this specific lawsuit would invent an event. The scene's function is to make a memory momentarily stir inside him. The missing judicial outcome must be described as unresolved.

Two Reputations: The City's Corridors and the Village's Memory

Batuknath gradually acquires a contested reputation in the corridors of the city court, a reputation Dīpālī cannot accept. At the same time the village preserves the memory of his earlier honest self. Thus two social narratives coexist around one person. It is not merely a portrait of hypocrisy but an example of how a "name" changes in significance: it is shaped by present actions and inherited recollection alike. Keeping the former image alive does not cancel his current conduct.

Burhbā's Protection of a Name: Not Acquittal but the Possibility of Change

Burhbā proposes holding Batuknath's name in hope rather than under a curse. Preservation of memory here does not amount to approval of wrongdoing. It keeps open an ethical possibility that the man might change direction. A lawyer who manipulates legal provisions against the poor is not relieved of criticism. By this extension, the novel's practice of remembering names is no longer restricted to a sacred inventory of innocent dead people: a morally compromised living person also enters it. The difficulty enriches the ethics of memory.

The General Allegation of the "Courtroom Lament" and the Particular Journey in Prose

The song "Courtroom Lament" speaks broadly of justice being sold beneath the lawyer's coat. The prose, however, makes the indispensable qualification that Batuknath once defended the poor. The song's embattled rhythm flattens temporal variation; the prose retains gradual transformation. If the song is taken as the whole immutable history of the character, his earlier commitment to justice and that later instant of remembrance disappear. Reading the two layers together produces a more realistic moral criticism.

Unequal Vision and Voice: Where Is Batuknath's Own Story?

The narrator describes the transformation, Dīpālī offers an anguished judgement, and Burhbā explains its possible causes. Batuknath himself receives no sustained speech. The poor widow likewise remains almost mute. In this threefold external assessment, inner life is suggested rather than voiced through independent confession. Decisive moral language belongs to the custodians of communal memory. This limits the novel's polyphony, though the momentary flash of village-memory prevents Batuknath from becoming nothing but an object of their judgement.

An Incomplete Return Within the Story's Structure

By the end Batuknath has not returned fully to his former honest course. The village keeps his name with hope, while society recognises his troubling professional reputation. The unresolved condition leaves a thread for future developments. The possible relation between this character and Ujjwal, introduced in [–34], exists as anticipation rather than as an event that has already brought them together. By placing another element within a future web, the chapter builds suspense instead of insisting on a linear resolution.

Overall Assessment: The System's Shadow and the Character's Unfinished Life

The greatest achievements of Batuknath's story are the gradation of his professional change, the encounter with the widow, and the simultaneous existence of two reputations. The old delay in seeking justice from [−68] returns through a new life; it is presented as historical recurrence rather than a curse. Its chief limitations are the absence of developed cases, the widow's voice, and Batuknath's self-examination. Once the song's general allegations are distinguished from the prose, he emerges as potentially capable of reform but presently caught in a moral crisis.

Source Basis, Uncertainty, and the Next Chapter

This reading draws on Batuknath's early honesty, his changing relations with powerful clients, Dīpālī and Burhbā's conversation, the unnamed poor widow's land dispute, the instant of village-memory, and his two reputations. No specified judicial order, result of the widow's case, future repentance, or proven criminal collaboration with another character appears here. In [−32], a possible face of the unidentified overseas network enters the narrative through a newspaper.

Critical Section 69 | Original Chapter −32 — Shadows Across the Sea

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

An Expanding Narrative Horizon: From the Village to Overseas

Chapter [−36] showed an unseen fraud depriving a young villager of his money; [−35] placed human freedom in danger through overseas employment. In [−32] the narrator situates these crises within the possible extension of an international financial network. A tall building abroad signals that the fictional geography is expanding, but the chapter does not actually stage a journey from the village to Hong Kong. A newspaper report and Burhbā's remembered perception bridge the distance. The reader gains a sense of extended geography without directly experiencing it. The narrative's representation is mediated rather than eyewitness.

"Shadows" in the Title: Absence More Than Visible Presence

The title evokes "shadows" beyond the sea. Their tangible forms are a newspaper report, a photograph of a tower, and a repeated name. No secret leader arrives in the village; the reader sees no personal workplace or independent activity. The shadow marks the boundary of what can be seen rather than taking complete possession of the scene. Narratologically, incompleteness gives the fear its power: the reader imagines an approaching centre in a place the story has not shown. A shadow is an analogy for uncertain news, however, not evidence of a living supernatural ghost.

Abhinav's Entrance: A Character as Reader of the News

Dīpālī's son Abhinav reads a newspaper report and goes beneath the peepal. He is neither a directly injured victim of financial fraud nor an investigator. His role is that of an anxious reader. The act of reading journalism brings the outside world into a village conversation. After Dīpālī's notebook and Vibhā's government papers, the newspaper is another form of written mediation. Through Abhinav's selection and interpretation of the report, the questions and fears attached to external material enter the story. Information travels from one place to another through a person's reading.

The Glass Tower: Height, Brilliance, and Internal Obscurity

The newspaper photograph shows a tall glass tower in a distant city. Height and brilliance make the exterior visible, while the suggestion of unseen

forces "inside" creates an opposing invisibility. The surface of the building is displayed, but the narrative provides no separate, complete evidence of what happens within. The contrast recalls the attractive market objects in [−45] and the plausible appearance of the fake website in [−36]. Even so, the story supplies only limited independent evidence that the photographed building is precisely the office of the criminals. The image's rhetorical certainty exceeds what is directly shown.

The Description of Financial Flows: "Wire by Wire" as Summary

The narrator says that money extracted from poor hands crosses several countries through wires and reaches unseen hands. Repetition in the phrase "wire by wire" suggests a rapid contraction of distance and the secret mobility of transactions. The prose identifies no particular bank, amount, account, date, corporation, or intermediary. Rather than a technical map of finance, the passage offers a fictional image of interconnected criminal power. The actual route of the money remains incomplete for the reader. It should be understood as world-building, not a fully documented financial mechanism.

A Name in the Report: The Narrative Emergence of Lau Kin-Hung

Abhinav says that the name "Lau Kin-Hung" occurs repeatedly in the newspaper report. Repetition gathers fear around an intelligible designation: an anonymous financial force seems, for the first time, to acquire a pronounceable name. Yet Abhinav himself says he does not know who this person is. That confession of uncertainty is decisive. Mere appearance of a name in a news story does not establish the person's guilt, command of a criminal network, or future enmity with Ujjwal. The narrative offers the beginning of identification, not a fully disclosed character.

Information Held by Characters and the Narrator's Omniscience

Abhinav supplies the information that a name appears in the report; Burhbā responds by referring to an ancient glimpse of his own. A journalistic text and an experience preserved in memory accumulate around one possible name. But their conjunction is not a scene of complete corroboration. The full newspaper text is not reproduced, nor is Burhbā's entire remembered episode. Rather than giving readers a definitive criminal history, the narrator directs uncertain signs towards a possible future point of convergence. Mystery arises from this disciplined allocation of information.

Burhbā's Strange Voice: An Old Memory Becomes Future Fear

Burhbā answers in a voice Abhinav has never heard before. By altering the voice of the long-lived custodian of memory, the narrator intensifies apprehension. Burhbā recalls an earlier glimpse of a glass tower but cannot say who the person may be or why that figure might become connected with Ujjwal and Batuknath. This ignorance carries long-term narrative force. The strange sound of his voice signifies not superior certainty but dread of events still to come.

The Possible Convergence of Three Names: The Construction of Foreshadowing

Burhbā raises the possibility of a connection among Ujjwal, Batuknath, and the shadow beyond the sea. Chapter [−34] introduced the newborn Ujjwal, [−33] presented the lawyer in moral crisis, and [−32] offers the uncertain name Lau Kin-Hung. Readers can arrange these strands into the image of a future web, but the three have not yet met or spoken at a single location. The promise of convergence generates narrative expectation. Rigorous narratological reading leaves the signs as signs rather than inventing the result of the coming plot.

"The Crocodile Changes Its Water": Fear Moving Through Historical Time

Burhbā says that the crocodile lived first in the pond, then in the screen, and now in a tower across the sea. In this figurative migration the novel's original aquatic creature becomes a continuing emblem for changing forms of exploitation. The comparison establishes one emotional thread across historically different settings. Nevertheless the pond's creature, an unidentified website operator, and a person mentioned in a report occupy different ontological and evidential levels. Treating them as the several bodies of one literally continuous criminal would destroy the metaphorical structure. Analogy identifies recurring features; it must not erase historical differences.

From Water to Glass: A New Contrast of Materials

The water of the paired pond, the roots of the peepal, and the distant glass tower meet within the conversation. Water remains the locality's store of remembrance and fear; the peepal is the gathering-place of the village's shared voice; glass presents the brilliance of remote finance. Differences in physical material figure unequal relations. Geography is not merely a decorative backdrop: its transformations suggest how far away and inaccessible the suspected power has become. The actual geography of international finance is not, however, mapped in detail.

Abhinav's Warning: A Possible Response, Not Complete Control

At the end Abhinav warns the village's young people about international proposals of fraud, recurring names, and movements of money. The circulation of warnings is an actual response. But the text narrates no investigation of an international syndicate, arrest, prosecution, or recovery of money. Burhbā's assurance that even a distant shadow will be weakened by the village's light is directed towards the future, not an account of an already achieved result. The distinction preserves the chapter's tension.

The Silent Source Behind the Report: No Named Journalist

The story describes the report's subject but gives no byline, publication date, headline, journalistic source, or photographer. The newspaper is an external text whose material is selectively communicated through dialogue. Thompson's book in [–57] distorted local experience through its classifications; here journalism initiates concern within the village. External writing is therefore not uniformly a hero or villain within the novel. It is a medium capable of several roles, the details and authority of which must be distinguished.

Narrative Time: A Present Report and an Earlier Glimpse

Abhinav's act of reading is part of the present action; Burhbā's remembered glimpse belongs to an unspecified earlier time; the anticipated "one day" lies ahead. All three temporal layers collect in one conversation beneath the peepal. This concentration allows a chapter with few material events to become an important link in the long narrative. Temporal arrangement does more work than direct physical action.

The Song's Certain "Mark" and the Prose's Incomplete Source

The song "Tower and Roots" expresses confidence that a mark will remain on the page by which a distant deceiver may be recognised. The prose contains a name printed in a newspaper, but not a fully established identity or judicial outcome. The song offers collective faith in the preservation of traces; the prose shows only the name, photograph, and anxiety. Turning the certainty of the song into a proved criminal identification would be an emotional overreach. The literary tension depends on the separate operation of these levels.

The Moral Image of an Unknown Criminal: The Danger of Simple Demonisation

Burhbā's dialogue represents the shadow as a power capable of deceiving people at a distance. Yet the characters explicitly acknowledge their lack of knowledge about the actual named person. Critical discussion must

examine the construction of an accusatory moral image without treating the mere sound of a name as conviction. The symbol of a frightening, uncertain name is effective, but the independent personality of the figure remains undisclosed. Recognising the danger of premature interpretation is part of fidelity to the text.

Overall Assessment: A Diagram of a Future Web

The chapter's power comes from gathering three unfinished character-strands beneath an international horizon of danger, the vivid glass-tower image, and the layered temporality of the earlier glimpse. A scarcity of directly dramatised events becomes a strength for foreshadowing. The account does not disclose the path of money through particular accounts, the true overseas operators, or the named person's proven role. It should therefore be read not as a completed inquiry but as the casting of a shadow over events still to come.

Source Boundaries and the Next Section

The source for this analysis is confined to the song in [–32], the report Abhinav reads, the photograph associated with Hong Kong, his fear concerning the name Lau Kin-Hung, Burhbā's earlier glimpse, and the communal warning. The actual identity of a perpetrator or a conspiracy linking all three characters is not established here. Chapter [–31] moves from the obscure overseas source to suspicious transactions inside a bank and to one employee's moral silence.

Critical Section 70 | Original Chapter −31 — Satyavrat's Silence

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

From the Distant Shadow into a Bank: Narrowing Narrative Vision

Chapter [−32] approached an overseas financial network uncertainly through journalism and an earlier glimpse; [−31] directs attention to transactions in a bank in the city. The change of setting shifts the narrative from an unknown global expanse towards local administrative detail. The narrator shows unusual account activity, but no actual incident directly connects those accounts with the Hong Kong report or Lau Kin-Hung. Similar subject matter may induce readers to infer a link; a causal relationship nevertheless remains an open question in this text. Mystery depends upon that gap.

An Introduction as "Quiet, Honest": The Character's Initial Form

Satyavrat Mehta enters as a quiet, honest young man employed at a city bank. The narrator first establishes his habitual restraint: he speaks little and observes much. This characterisation lends credibility to his approaching dilemma, for he does not immediately expose the irregularity he notices. Silence, however, is not predetermined evidence of complicity. The opening also explicitly ascribes honesty to him. His character is built from the conflict between being a reliable observer and a hesitant speaker.

Plural Meanings of Silence: Disposition, Protection, and Possible Fault

The song distinguishes silence that offers protection from silence that permits injustice. The prose does not grant Satyavrat's restraint a single fixed ethical meaning. His junior position, inequality of authority, fear, and the need to gather more information are all present as possible reasons. Burhbā leaves the weight of decision with him. Silence is therefore an action whose meaning changes with time and circumstance, not a stable vice. Reducing the chapter to "silence equals guilt" would dissolve both the occupational risks and the uncertainty implicit in Burhbā's counsel.

The Movement of Money: The Visual Rhythm of Repetition

Satyavrat watches a large sum enter an account, immediately disperse among several others, move onward, and ultimately vanish from view. Verbs of arriving, dividing, and disappearing give the financial activity a

rapid rhythm. The narrator identifies no exact number of accounts, complete sum, final beneficiary, or transaction date. The scene establishes a specific ground for suspicion without giving a full criminal inquiry. Banking becomes visible as the movement of money, while the human faces behind it remain concealed.

"Lakhs" as Quantity: An Index of Concern, Not an Accounts Table

The prose says that "lakhs" enter one account. This conveys the movement of substantial money; it is not a precise ledger total. It would be erroneous to convert the word into an invented number of lakhs, a total amount defrauded, or a quantified loss. Satyavrat later writes down dates and details, but the contents of his ledger are not shown to the reader. The language of measurement remains deliberately limited, allowing the ethical predicament rather than financial arithmetic to dominate the scene.

The Inequality of Power Within a "Junior Employee"

Satyavrat considers himself a junior employee and asks: Who will listen? What danger might follow if I speak? The questions reveal the institutional hierarchy of a bank. Money may move freely among accounts, but the authority to speak about its movement, the prospect of protection, and the chance of being heard are unequally distributed. The story introduces no manager, senior official, audit committee, or individual who actually threatens him; his apprehension remains an anticipation of risk. Despite this indeterminacy, the position of limited power is narratively convincing: seeing everything is not the same as having the power to change it.

Returning to the Village: Translating Institutional Anxiety into a Domestic Conversation

On leave Satyavrat comes beneath the peepal and tells Burhbā of his predicament. The bank's transactions become a question of practical judgement within the village. Burhbā does not act as a judicial specialist in financial systems. He discusses how to recognise a moment for decision. The change of scene allows the reader to approach economic irregularities through communal ethics. The conversation does not itself put an end to the questionable activities. The peepal is a place of deliberation, not an investigative banking office.

Burhbā Does Not Appropriate the Decision

"I cannot make the decision for you" is an unusually important admission by Burhbā. He has offered unambiguous advice in many earlier chapters; here he acknowledges Satyavrat's independent responsibility. The moral

authority and the fear associated with the decision remain in the employee's hands. Burhbā proposes a limited direction: write down what you have seen and recognise the appropriate time to speak. Such restraint softens the character's usually authoritative didactic stance and preserves the uncertainty of an individual's choice.

"The Moment to Speak": A Temporal Division in Ethics

Both song and dialogue make the value of silence depend upon time. Remaining silent before the proper moment may be patience; remaining silent once it has come may become injustice. Ethics is made into the difficulty of recognising a moment. That "moment", however, is not defined by an exact hour or objective test. Consequently the story does not remove suspense. Satyavrat must continue towards a decision through subsequent experience. His uncertainty is the motor of the episode, not a problem to be abolished by a premature critical verdict.

The Notebook: The Visible Contradiction of Silence

Back in the city Satyavrat begins recording dates, amounts, and the movement of money among accounts. He still does not speak publicly, yet he accumulates information through writing. Silence ceases to be a wholly passive void and becomes potential preparation for testimony. The notebook enters as an ethical instrument, but the text offers no reproduction of its pages, monetary amounts, names, or bank documents. The act of recording is visible; its complete contents are not. The object is surrounded by possible future importance.

An Earlier Model of Secret Writing: From Yādavānand to Satyavrat

Yādavānand's Shadow Register preserved village history under dangerous conditions; Satyavrat's notebook contains observations of suspicious financial activities. In each case a person unable or unwilling to speak openly invests energy in private writing. Their subjects are different: the first concerns collective names, the second financial transactions. Their similarity lies in the narrative form of clandestine recording, not in the equivalence of their evidentiary contents. This repetition prepares a layered history of documentation for the following chapter about Gop Kumar's archive.

An Undeclared Future: "It Will One Day Be Important"

The concluding sentence indicates that Satyavrat does not know the future significance of his notebook. Here the narrator claims anticipatory knowledge beyond that of the character. The foreshadowing directs attention from the pages being written to events not yet narrated. It does not show the notebook being presented in court, an offender being

caught, or the victims receiving restitution. Distinguishing prospective use from an accomplished consequence is a condition of precise reading.

Global Suspicion and a Local Account: An Unresolved Connection

Chapter [−32] described a possible financial network thousands of miles away; here Satyavrat notices apparently irregular movements of money in an urban bank. Their consecutive arrangement invites the reader to regard them as parts of one story. Yet the phrase “suspicious funds” does not establish a single criminal owner behind both episodes. No document yet connects Satyavrat's accounts with the tower beyond the sea. The achievement lies in the provisional parallel, which encourages something like investigative curiosity.

Voices Unheard: Where Are the Bank's Victims and Colleagues?

The chapter centres on Satyavrat's solitary observation. The holders of the suspect accounts, potential victims, colleagues, and senior officers do not speak. The social scope of the possible irregularity is therefore not represented through a range of independent voices. The narrator has made silence the theme without constructing a many-character exchange in the workplace. The selection increases mystery and Satyavrat's moral isolation; a fully developed collective conflict over finance is deferred.

The Internal Tension of the Song “Silent Testimony”

The song anticipates the moment when Satyavrat's silence will amount to consequential testimony. In the prose he has only begun to record account activity. The song is an ethical prelude to a possible later result, not its complete dramatic enactment. Testimony usually involves speaking before an audience or institution; the private notebook has not yet become a public presentation of evidence. The contrast permits us to see both the song's emotional firmness and the prose's cautious temporal incompleteness.

A Psychological Image of Risk: Fear Named, Threat Unnamed

Satyavrat expresses fear, but no identifiable person is shown threatening him. He anticipates dangers arising from the hierarchy of his workplace. Psychological suspense can be formed without an external depiction of punishment: unequal rank, apparently contaminated financial flows, and the sense of solitary responsibility produce anxiety together. The indistinct source of risk leaves a question for later. Fear is an experience the character actually has, though not all possible causes are proved external events.

Principal Achievement: The Delay Between Writing and Speaking

The chapter's aesthetic force lies in the unresolved patience of a junior employee, the changing ethical meaning of silence, and the notebook's anticipatory position. By postponing exposure, the author makes the work of preparation visible. Missing transaction details, the forum of future testimony, other employees' voices, and a decisive action form meaningful gaps for later narrative development. Moral resolve presently takes the form of private documentary labour; openly declared heroism has not yet occurred.

Source Examination and the Next Connection

Chapter [−31] provides Satyavrat Mehta's employment, his observation of unusual transactions, the peepal dialogue, restraint, and the dated notebook. It supplies neither an accomplished whistleblowing outcome, a final determination of bank crime, nor a verified link with the overseas group. Chapter [−30] expands the act of keeping records from an individual's private notebook towards a collection containing centuries of the village's documents.

Critical Section 71 | Original Chapter −30 — Gop Kumar's Documents

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

From a Private Notebook to a Collective Archive: The Narrative Expands

In [−31], Satyavrat silently records the details of suspicious transactions; in [−30], Gop Kumar brings together old registers, maps, and digital records. Both chapters centre upon written objects, but their purposes and temporal reach differ. Satyavrat's notebook is prospective testimony about an immediate danger; Gop Kumar's collection seeks to preserve names and events across centuries. Consequently, writing becomes more than the accumulation of words: it is the act of reorganising relations between time and community. The recurrence of documentary labour is not an empty repetition. It shifts the function of the record from possible disclosure of a present irregularity towards the wider reconstruction of a collective past.

Gop Kumar's Beginnings: From the Smell of Paper to a Life Among Records

The narrator recalls Gop Kumar's childhood pleasure in smelling old paper and reading names, and then describes how, as a young man, he devoted his life to research and the collection of documents. The abbreviated life-history moves from inclination to sustained practice. It does not, however, supply a separate biography of his education, employment, personal income, or domestic difficulties. His identity is constituted principally through fidelity to collecting. The character's chosen activity and the novel's concern with remembering itself almost coincide. That convergence gives him structural importance, even as the private circumstances that might complicate a life devoted to archival labour remain largely outside the frame.

"Old Leaves, New Screens": The Simultaneity of Media

The song and the prose gather old registers, maps, papers obtained from the government, and new records assembled on screens into a single collection. Technological succession here does not mean that the newer medium eliminates the older: the media are used concurrently. In [−44], the first computer permitted the typing of a line of folk song; Gop Kumar expands that possibility by bringing material in different forms together. Yet the chapter does not describe the architecture of a complete digital repository, file standards, storage locations, or backup procedures. It offers

an image of relationships among media, not a technical manual. The aesthetic significance of this coexistence lies in preserving differences of provenance while making connections possible.

Yādavānand and Vibhā: Written Remains of Two Historical Periods

Gop Kumar joins the register written by Yādavānand at night to government papers Vibhā obtained by exercising the right to information. One document is the survival of clandestine labour; the other is the achievement of a public right. Bringing them together prevents the village's history from becoming solely the state's version or solely a secret local remembrance. Nevertheless, the narrative does not reproduce every page, show conflicting entries, or dramatise the difficulties of reconciling discrepancies. Its emphasis falls upon the activity of assembling rather than upon an extended dispute among records. The structure of archival accomplishment is clear; the form of possible documentary disagreement remains comparatively undeveloped.

Map and Register: Memories of Place and Memories of Names

An old map concerns the arrangement of places; a register preserves people's names, events, and relationships. By joining the two, Gop Kumar opens the possibility of reading changes in water, embankments, fields, and the village itself alongside its inhabitants' histories. The original chapter does not, however, provide the geography of a particular map or a detailed account of every alteration marked on it. The map signals diversity within the collection rather than furnishing a complete spatial history. The distinction matters to this social narrative: a list of names does not exist independently of the places in which lives unfolded, yet a promised connection between geography and biography is not the same as an exhaustive reconstruction of both.

The Recurring "Thread": An Image for Joining Scattered Stories

The narrator says that Gop Kumar joins separate leaves as though adding "one thread at a time". A thread need not refer to the literal material used in binding; it is also a metaphor for establishing relationships. It draws together stories interrupted across generations, clandestine registers, and modern digital entries. Yet bringing documents into one collection does not automatically make their claims agree or their accounts equally reliable. The narrative seldom pauses over a concrete contradiction between documents. As a result, the thread expresses the beauty of connection while risking a simplification of archival work's genuinely difficult aspects. Collection can be achieved without all the questions raised by its contents being resolved.

Gop Kumar's Question: When Is a Story Ready to Become a Book?

Gop Kumar asks Burhbā whether the time has come to gather the entire story into one place. The question makes the novel contemplate its own process of composition. In ordinary narrative, events happen; here a character asks when events acquire the right, or the readiness, to be written as a whole. Burhbā does not immediately authorise publication: he says that one final chapter remains. The self-reflexive nature of the exchange is explicit. The work acknowledges, through the dialogue of its characters, that its anticipated totality is still incomplete. The archive may be under construction, but the circumstances that would make the narrative ready for a conclusion have not yet been presented.

Haripati the Poet's Earlier Question: The Story Remembers Its Own Writing

Burhbā recalls the question Haripati the poet asked long ago: when should the story be written? That remembrance makes Gop Kumar's present labour the distant outcome of a dispute about writing established much earlier. It also connects to the printing-press episode in [−63], where possession of a means of publication did not signify that a story had reached completion. Technical capacity and narrative closure are distinct conditions. Through Burhbā's speech, the enormous span of the novel is compressed into a single conversation. The contemporary narrative, however, is still awaiting a decisive event that has not been shown. Remembering the earlier question does not resolve it by itself.

"One Final Chapter": A Character's Claim, Not the Book's Last Page

Burhbā declares that "one final chapter" remains. This is a forward-looking statement by a character, not evidence that the last page of the original 301-chapter novel has arrived. The chapter under discussion is [−30], and many original chapters follow it. "Final chapter" may refer to the decisive event Burhbā expects or to a moment at which the village's collection of stories could be judged sufficiently complete. In any case, the character's desired conclusion must be distinguished from the actual architecture of the book. The statement is a device of anticipatory self-commentary, not an unalterable timetable for publication or proof of an accomplished ending.

Ujjwal, Batuknath, and the Distant Shadow: Three Threads Rejoined

Burhbā speaks of Ujjwal, Batuknath, and the distant shadow as figures who may participate in the difficult events ahead. Chapter [−34] presented Ujjwal's uncertain future, [−33] Batuknath's ethical predicament, and [−32] a name of uncertain significance from overseas. The present conversation

brings these threads together as a possible future convergence. It does not depict the three characters meeting, forming an alliance, or entering into a shared conflict. The device makes the author's prospective organisation of events visible, but its foreshadowing cannot be treated as evidence of a conspiracy that has already occurred. The force of the passage depends upon holding possibility open.

"To Become a Witness": The Narrative Responsibility of the Collector

According to Burhbā, collecting is not "decoration"; it means becoming a witness. His assertion raises Gop Kumar's work above the level of merely copying or filing papers. The person who joins histories of happiness, suffering, and injustice must accept the emotional burden attached to them. The question of how a book is made thus becomes an ethical matter within the book itself. Yet this principle is voiced by Burhbā. Gop Kumar's own extended inner struggle over the collected suffering is not narrated. The obligation of authorship is powerfully declared, but the archivist's interior experience of carrying it remains only partially disclosed.

A Lost Name from an Old Flood: One Concrete Moment in the Collection

While examining the old register, Gop Kumar finds a name lost in a flood centuries earlier, with a brief note in Yādavānand's handwriting beside it. This scene gives the otherwise abstract work of collecting a tangible instant. A forgotten or dead person's name enters a new record, allowing the recovery and renewed circulation of a name to become narratively visible. But the name itself is not spoken for the reader, and the note is not quoted. We therefore cannot identify the recovered person or reconstruct the exact circumstances of the disappearance or death. The moment gains emotional force from the paper, even as the specific identity it is said to restore remains inaccessible to the reader.

The Paradox of an Unnamed Name: A Gap Between Theme and Representation

The chapter's governing commitment is to preserve "every lost name", but the old name recovered in its most significant scene is not actually given to the reader. It would be inadequate simply to dismiss this tension as an error: it reveals a limit of narrative representation. The story depicts an ethical victory for the preservation of names while reducing an individual remembrance to the abstract expression "a name". The question of numerous unnamed dead is integral to a vast, multigenerational saga; nevertheless, the failure to pronounce this particular name renders the collective undertaking partly impersonal. A declaration that a name was

recovered and the narrative act of naming the person are not identical achievements.

The Image of the "Bridge": A Dynamic Relationship Between Times

Gop Kumar experiences his task as more than joining papers: he is building a bridge between centuries. The metaphor makes time resemble a distance that can be crossed, allowing the name of a dead person to reach the village's present. Such a "return" is not the bodily rebirth of the lost individual; it is the possibility of reading the name again. The bridge differs from the figure of roots in [–41]. Roots suggested a durable basis of belonging, while a bridge enables passage between separated historical periods. Through this spatial image, the work renders its temporal construction intelligible and makes archival continuity appear as an active exchange rather than a merely fixed possession.

The Pace of Compilation: Present Labour and Deferred Completion

Gop Kumar is already engaged in joining the records, so the work of compilation has begun. Burhbā nevertheless places its completion after a final decisive episode. The two conditions are plainly different: ongoing work in the present and completeness postponed into the future. To describe the current chapter as the moment at which an entirely finished and published history of the village has appeared would contradict Burhbā's insistence upon waiting and the collector's continuing preparation. The accurate reading is of an archive under construction. This structural incompletion is part of the chapter's purpose, for it lets documentary labour continue while the narrative holds open the possibility of something that still demands witness.

Gop Kumar: Future Author or Merely Witness?

At the end, Gop Kumar thinks that he may become a witness to the final chapter, "perhaps its author too". The conditional force of "perhaps" matters. His future role is unsettled in two related ways: he may observe an event, and he may write it. The hesitation animates the novel's self-referential design because the reader does not yet know who will ultimately tell its concluding story. Earlier episodes have considered the authority of outside writers, the village's oral transmission, and the making of digital collections. Here the writer's identity returns as a question rather than a settled credential. Witnessing and authorship may overlap, but the prose has not declared their union inevitable.

The Authority to Write: Whose Stories Will the Collector Choose?

Gop Kumar intends to gather the "whole" history of the village, but the principle by which every name, injustice, and sorrow will be selected is not

described. Yādavānand's register, Vibhā's official documents, and the digital records originate in different historical and institutional circumstances. Which voices will remain and which will be lost is therefore an open issue. The narrative trusts Gop Kumar's project without presenting a full process for participation by marginalised people, correcting errors, or adjudicating editorial disagreement. Its ambition towards completeness and the difficulty of representation must be read together. A local collector is not automatically an infallible narrator merely because the materials are locally held.

Archival "Immortality": A Figure for Resisting Time

Villagers imagine Gop Kumar as someone seeking immortality for memory, and the song makes documents contend with time. The narrative does not establish that paper and digital files are indestructible, permanently accessible, or capable of filling every gap in remembrance. Immortality here is a communal hope and an image of writing as resistance. Its meaning lies in action against the fear of forgetting over generations, not in any guaranteed technical permanence. This distinction does not diminish the metaphor's beauty. Rather, it identifies the domain in which it works: the aspiration to transmit memory, accompanied by sustained effort, in a world where every record can remain vulnerable.

The Combined Authority of Oral Memory and Written Records

Burhbā's long oral memory guides Gop Kumar's assembling, while paper and digital media give that work material forms. Spoken remembrance is therefore not the enemy of the written archive; it is among the conditions from which the archive draws meaning. Unlike the external scholar's distorted presentation in [–57], Gop Kumar seeks to edit from within the village's own perspective. Local authorship, however, does not by itself ensure impartiality or the absence of documentary error. The achievement is to bring the question "who has the right to tell the story?" into sustained relation with technology and historical time, not to prove that the final narrative must be perfectly complete.

Overall Critical Judgement: A Narrative Confronting Its Own Book Form

Chapter [–30] becomes a centre of self-reflection in the long trilogy. Its characters are no longer only people who undergo history; they are possible makers of its record. Yādavānand's hidden register, Vibhā's publicly obtained papers, Satyavrat's private notebook, and Gop Kumar's comprehensive collection represent different practices of writing. Burhbā's postponement of the "final chapter" creates an expectation of eventual convergence. Yet the scarcity of actual documentary contents, the

omission of the recovered person's name, and the limited depiction of editorial difficulty remain significant constraints. This is not a scene in which the complete collection is announced as finished: it is the threshold before the whole story might be written.

Textual Basis, Limits of Evidence, and the Next Chapter

This analysis rests upon the song "Written Inheritance" in Chapter [–30], Gop Kumar's attraction to old papers, the gathering of Yādavānand's and Vibhā's documents, Burhbā's recollection of Haripati's question, the foreshadowing involving Ujjwal, Batuknath, and the distant shadow, the reappearance of an unnamed name from an old flood, and Gop Kumar's possible authorship. Neither a completed published collection nor the anticipated decisive meeting takes place in this chapter. The next section, [–29], "Chandrapal's Dream", will take the story onwards towards the future of labour, signatures, and particular risks within the digital network.

Critical Section 72 | Original Chapter −29 — Chandrapal's Dream

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

A Story of Birth Versus the Prehistory of a Fall

At first sight, the title “Chandrapal's Dream” promises an account of his aspirations and of their eventual collapse. The opening folk song condenses the image of a betting trap, a signature placed without understanding, and deception; the introductory editorial sentence likewise anticipates a law degree and entanglement in a web of fraud. The principal narrative prose, however, remains with Chandrapal's birth, Burhbā's uneasiness, and the decision to enter his name in the record. This difference is central to the construction of the chapter. The possibility of danger reaches the reader in advance, while the life represented in the scene is still in infancy. To treat the song's knowledge of a possible future as a fraud committed on the night of his birth would mistake one narrative level for another.

Three Layers at the Opening: Proverb, Song, and Prose

The proverb, “One whose eyes hold a dream may find deception at his feet,” establishes a general moral pattern. The song places Chandrapal within that pattern; the prose locates him in a particular social and genealogical situation. Their information is not interchangeable. The proverb articulates a principle of risk; the song presents possible future events in language that nearly makes them sound completed; the prose represents the restricted present of a birth. Readers must therefore accommodate three different temporal circuits at once. Flattening these layered utterances into a single linear synopsis would destroy the chapter's carefully maintained tension between anticipation and narrated occurrence.

Meerut: The Enlargement of the Narrative Beyond the Village

Chandrapal Batra is born in Meerut. His family left the village years earlier, moved through several towns, and eventually settled there. Its connection with Garh Narikel now survives chiefly as an old family name and occasional letters. The narrator measures distance not simply geographically but by the attenuation of living relationships. Even while the village remains the novel's habitual stage, a potentially important character enters the story through a birth elsewhere. This extension of the narrative's territorial reach is significant. Yet the prose does not depict

Chandrapal himself coming to the village in the present chapter. A broader horizon of affiliation is established without inventing a journey that has not taken place.

Burhbā's Disquiet: Premonition Rather Than Complete Knowledge

On the night of Chandrapal's birth, Burhbā is troubled. Villagers wonder why he should be distressed by a child born far away and barely known to them. The text does not turn his disturbance into a complete vision of the boy's future. He indicates that the child will eventually enter the story to which he bears witness; he does not provide a sequence of definite outcomes. His emotional condition intensifies the reader's expectation, but the causal history remains withheld. Premonition here is an instrument for delaying disclosure rather than a substitute for the story whose events have yet to unfold.

Gop Kumar's Question: Testing the Limits of Witnessing

Gop Kumar's direct objection is that the child does not belong to the village. In asking this, he functions as more than a listener: he becomes an internal reader who tests the boundaries of the narrative's community. Burhbā's response weakens the assumption that birth upon the village's soil is the necessary condition for inclusion. Without the question, the archival category of a "distant connection" might seem a purely administrative addition. Through dialogue, it becomes both a dramatic turn and a conceptual examination of who may belong to a community's remembered history.

The Geography of the Net and the Geography of Memory

In Burhbā's account the "new crocodile" of wires and screens does not recognise village or national boundaries. If memory is to offer protection against its reach, the practice of witnessing must extend beyond the village embankment. The narrator gives no actual technical map of the digital network; spatial boundlessness is conveyed through an image rather than demonstrated by an investigation. A worldwide fraud apparatus is not proved in this birth chapter. Its possible reach, however, supplies a narrative reason for redefining membership in the village's memory. The community's horizon changes in response to a danger that is anticipated, not yet directly encountered here.

The Name: From Genealogical Connection to Narrative Connection

Chandrapal's family has only a distant connection with the village, yet his anticipated story is linked to the wider narrative of Garh Narikel. A name here is not merely proof of blood descent; it marks a possible future entrance into the story. Burhbā accepts the name on the day of birth; Gop

Kumar subsequently accords it a place within the archival system. The first act is one of memorial recognition, the second one of editorial arrangement. The child has no articulated inner consciousness in the episode. His name is granted a narrative position before his distinctive personal character has developed.

"Distant Relations": A New Archival Classification

Gop Kumar creates a separate division in his digital collection for people connected to the village but born elsewhere. That small action changes the logic of the long novel's records. Earlier registers sought to recover overlooked names within local social experience. Now the archive expands to accommodate future participants without demanding that they be born within the same geographical boundary. Chandrapal is the first entry in this category. The organisational change is an actual narrated event, although the text does not provide a complete list of other distant relations or a formal rule for selecting them. The archival reach is enlarged, not rendered all-knowing.

The Unequal Durations of the Present Scene and Distant Future

The action of the principal prose occupies little more than the night of birth and the concern surrounding it. Yet that present encompasses the family's migration years earlier, apprehensions of a later crisis, and a chronology that cannot yet be known. A restricted scene is thus bordered by an extended past and an open future. Such temporal compression gives the small event a disproportionate significance. It does not supply the intervening history of Chandrapal's education, adulthood, or financial risk. Those unwritten intervals must remain unwritten in criticism as well, rather than being filled with conjectural episodes.

Burhbā's "Watch": The Changing Scope of Collective Vigilance

The older practice of witnessing preserved names after death or during a recognised crisis. Here Burhbā keeps the name of a newborn who may eventually confront a form of digital deception. Remembering begins to function as anticipatory vigilance rather than exclusively retrospective commemoration. Still, no concrete measure of protection, instruction given to the family, or agreement from the child is represented in this scene. The "watch" is expansive as a figure of communal responsibility, but its immediate practical content is the archival entry. The gap between the moral force of remembrance and its capacity to prevent injury remains evident.

The Reader Knows More Than Chandrapal

Chandrapal, being a newborn, knows nothing of his possible future, his connection with the village, or Gop Kumar's new category. Through the song, introductory commentary, and Burhbā's anxiety, the reader acquires more indications than the character possesses. This asymmetry initiates dramatic irony: the reader anticipates danger while the child is unaware of the story into which he has been placed. Yet even the reader's additional knowledge is incomplete. An impression that trouble may come is not evidence that the trouble has already occurred. Respecting that difference is indispensable to the chapter's chronology.

A New Knot in the Long Genealogical Structure

This chapter follows immediately after "Gop Kumar's Documents." There the proposed collection of village memory awaited a decisive event; here its scope suddenly extends as far as Meerut. The expansion does not indicate that the final story has already arrived. Rather, a possible participant in it is beginning to be identified. A new character is born before the previous generations' stories have conclusively ended. Such succession makes the trilogy less a chain of completed biographies than an ongoing process of witnessing, in which one narrative connection is formed while others remain unresolved.

From Occasional Letters to the Digital Net: Degrees of Mediation

The distant family's relationship with the village has been reduced to occasional letters. Gop Kumar's digital archive now places that intermittent connection within a new scheme of remembrance. A letter carries delayed personal news; a digital collection is an organisational form for gathering information. The prose does not show a live conversation with Chandrapal's household, a video call, or automatic acquisition of their data. The new medium's strength appears symbolically and institutionally, not as technical omniscience. Distinguishing the functions of the older and newer media is essential to a credible reading of the novel's history of communication.

Whose Dream Does the Title Name?

The song links Chandrapal's dream to the possibility of deception, but the prose contains no internally experienced dream of Chandrapal himself. The word may designate a projected aspiration, Burhbā's fear, and the forecast implicit in the chapter's framing. What is established is the elder's agitation; what the child will want remains entirely undefined. The title therefore points towards a still-unfolding narrative direction rather than a conscious desire presently possessed by the named character. To invent the

newborn's thoughts would confound the suggestive title with an episode that the narrator has not supplied.

Stylistic Recurrence: Names and Boundaries

The song repeatedly links "name," "village," and "boundary"; Burhbā speaks of extending his watch beyond those boundaries; Gop Kumar translates the principle into a new archival category. The same vocabulary thus performs three different functions: poetic formula, dialogic decision, and administrative arrangement. This recurrence is not inert. The proposition with which the chapter begins becomes a materially identifiable alteration in the organisation of records. Ethical language creates an action, albeit an action whose effects on Chandrapal's later safety are not yet demonstrated.

A Critical Caution About the Limits of the Narrative

The introductory presentation and song anticipate a law degree, a betting network, and a fraudulent signature, but the principal prose gives no developed chronology, participants, or outcome for these possible events. The discrepancy between narrative levels is best understood as a prematurely disclosed future orientation. A synopsis declaring that a young man from Meerut has already lost money through betting would misplace later possibilities within the scene of his birth. Attention to what has not yet happened is as necessary to exact criticism as attention to the events explicitly described.

Overall Assessment: An Expanding Village, an Uncertain Future

The genuine innovation of Chapter [–29] is not a completed account of Chandrapal's financial ruin, but the enlargement of the village's remembered community at the time of his birth. The name of a distant relation born outside the village becomes the first entry in Gop Kumar's new archival division. Burhbā's unease generates expectation; the song hurries towards the future while the prose moves carefully within the present. Through this contrast, a regional narrative begins to open towards an extended digital world without prematurely resolving the life of the child who has just entered it.

Critical Section 73 | Original Chapter −28 — Raghav's Code

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

A Narrative Beginning with the Introduction of Talent

The chapter begins with the birth of a gifted child and a description of his exceptional ease with technology. Raghav belongs to Abhinav's branch of the family living in a town. The contrast between village children learning letters on coconut leaves and Raghav learning to understand code establishes the speed of his acquisition of new skills. Technology is not introduced as a senseless negation of earlier education, but as another linguistic world. Yet the celebration of aptitude is not a developed account of personality. The prose does not supply Raghav's political beliefs, close friendships, institutional employment, or future decisions. It establishes his possible capacity rather than completing his life story.

"Code": The Difference Between Medium and Character

The code named in the title is the language of a machine. The song suggests that every line of code conceals the name of the human hand that made it, thereby returning responsibility for technological processes to their makers. The prose does not describe a particular programming language, algorithm, or cyber tool. "Code" signifies technological power and the ethical choices governing its employment. Accordingly, Raghav's talent cannot be read as technical evidence that he has committed a specific crime. The narrative is more interested in the consciousness of the person who may choose a use for technical power than in the apparatus's detailed operation.

Two Possible Directions: Protection and Destruction

Burhbā is concerned that Raghav's skills might be used either to protect or to destroy. This is an ethical alternative, not an accomplished decision. The folk song is similarly conditional: if code preserves names, it has one meaning; if it erases them, it acquires another. The conditional form is crucial. It separates possible worlds from established facts about a future that has not unfolded. Raghav's ethical position may change as the story develops, but at present the text only opens the paths between which he might eventually choose. Its structural interest is anticipation rather than judgement.

The Compressed Iteration of Adolescent Skill

The narrator tells us that Raghav sometimes repairs complicated machines and sometimes detects hidden errors. Words such as "sometimes"

condense a succession of potentially complex incidents into a few sentences. No such incident is fully staged; together they establish a general impression of extraordinary ability. The years of adolescence pass rapidly in narrative discourse. The case of the poor village family's papers, however, receives particular emphasis and connects skill with an identifiable result. The alteration in pace allows the principal ethical issue to gain a concrete foothold amid more general descriptions of talent.

The Poor Family's Papers: An Observed Use of Skill

Raghav uses his technical ability to straighten out the confused and exhausted papers of a poor family from the village, enabling them to secure their entitlement. Technology thus serves as a means of actual assistance. The prose does not identify the office involved, the legal character of the forms, or the precise administrative procedure. It would be unjustified to say that he hacked an official system or altered a database. The narrated action is a beneficial intervention whose mechanism remains unspecified. Nor can one good deed guarantee all Raghav's future ethical decisions. It provides an important positive beginning, not an irrevocable verdict.

The Question Mark: A Future Left Open Within the Document

Gop Kumar adds a question mark beside Raghav's name. Rather than recording a settled judgement, the archive preserves a visible sign of uncertainty. This material punctuation can be read as a representation of the reader's own expectancy. In the preceding chapter Chandrapal's entry extended the archive geographically; here Raghav's entry gives it an explicitly ethical indeterminacy. A document is not merely a storehouse of past facts; it becomes an unfinished framework in which a future story may eventually find a place. The passage says time will fill the empty space, thus deferring the outcome instead of declaring it.

Narrative Distance in Judging the Character

Gop Kumar is excited by Raghav's potential, Burhbā remains cautious, and some elders consider whether his ability might facilitate deception as readily as assistance. These attitudes belong to different characters. They are not a single incontestable judgement pronounced by an omniscient narrator. Attending to this distribution of evaluation protects Raghav's complexity. We know that he has helped a poor family, and we know that others fear the possibilities of his skill. We do not yet know what kind of person he will ultimately become. The text suspends classification while placing competing expectations around him.

Coconut Leaves and Computers: The Changing Material of Education

Writing on coconut leaves and Raghav's education in code belong to the same extended educational thread of the novel. One medium enables the practice of handwritten letters; the other operates through digital signs. In this comparison, modernity does not simply enter from outside and erase remembered knowledge. It creates a new test of how memory may be protected. Raghav, emerging after the long history of the village school, becomes a prospective agent in the ethical application of technology. Yet the chapter does not specifically state that he himself attended the Coconut-Leaf School. The comparison is an educational figure, not a biographical fact about his enrolment.

The Sword Metaphor: How Neutral Is Technology?

Burhbā compares a skill to a sword whose employment depends upon the mind of the person wielding it. This is the character's pedagogical metaphor, a compact way of articulating Raghav's eventual choice. It should not be elevated into a comprehensive philosophical finding that all technologies are socially neutral. Access to equipment, distribution of resources, and opportunities for use also shape technical action, although this chapter does not undertake a detailed study of those institutional conditions. The critical task is to retain both the meaning of Burhbā's proposed principle and the limits of the narrative's account of technology.

Raghav's Silence: The Absence of Self-Narration

The chapter supplies Raghav's name, birth, abilities, and helpful conduct, but gives him no sustained direct account of his own intentions. Gop Kumar and Burhbā discuss his future choices; Raghav himself has little chance to explain what he wants. The structure makes him an unformed possibility about whom others speak more than a self-interpreting agent. His psychology therefore cannot responsibly be fixed in advance. The narrative leaves a tension between communal evaluation, which is already pressing upon the gifted child, and the independent choice which he may later make for himself.

The Developing Debate Between “Names” and “Numbers”

Earlier, in the computer episode, numbers were inadequate to encompass the particular life story carried by a name. Here the name can signify both the creator of code and the people affected by its use. The song's contrast between code that protects names and code that erases them transfers the old language of remembrance into technological ethics. A code that protects becomes a guardian; one that destroys becomes the crocodile. None of this furnishes a technical example of encryption, stolen name

data, or a damaged system. The song supplies a social and moral language rather than a programming specification.

Arranging Characters Before the Coming Shock

Amid the development of a new narrative of digital crime, Raghav's introduction supplies a possible opponent to predatory power—or potentially one of its collaborators. The emergence of technical skill alongside the threat of crime prevents the reader from facing a world of absolute helplessness, but rescue is not assured. Such advance positioning of a character is a recognisable device in an extended narrative, preparing relations whose consequences may mature much later. Whether Raghav will eventually stand against danger or be drawn towards it remains unanswered.

A Widening Geography: Towns, Village, and Archive

Chandrapal enters as a distant relation born in Meerut, while Raghav comes from Abhinav's town-dwelling family branch. Two consecutive chapters therefore bring important new figures into being outside the village's immediate territory. Gop Kumar's records draw both into a larger structure of remembered connection. Rather than furnishing extensive scenes of urban life, the narrative repeatedly brings news, names, and dialogue back to the village's established interpretive centre. In this manner the growth of the story's geography is mediated through information and record-keeping, not necessarily through journeys visibly made by the new characters.

The Exaggerated Language of the "Extraordinary"

Raghav's ability is likened to solving in an instant difficulties that might take engineers years. Such praise is markedly hyperbolic. The text offers no measurable examination of his proficiency or independent technical test. The narrator rapidly constructs a brilliant character through amplified attributes. This method has symbolic value, but it also raises a question for later characterisation: when extraordinary ability is assigned so early, the struggle through which a personality develops may be reduced. Whether subsequent episodes complicate that convenient beginning remains an open matter.

The Moral Instruction of Earlier Generations: Room for Independent Choice

Burhbā believes that Raghav could become a useful guardian if he remembers the village, exercises judgement, and respects names. But he explicitly admits that he does not know which direction the young man will choose. This admission prevents the elder's long memory from being

mistaken for total control of the future. Even within a prophetic atmosphere, the character's moral freedom is not abolished. Gop Kumar's question mark gives that uncertainty a visible material form. The future must supply its own evidence instead of merely fulfilling an interpretation already entered in the archive.

The Ratio Between Narrative Preparation and Dramatised Action

Much of the chapter describes Raghav's capacity and discusses the ethical meaning of that capacity. Only the episode involving a poor family's papers provides a clearly identifiable result. Announced potential and dramatised action are therefore distributed unequally. The reader receives more information about a large possible future than about the concrete struggles through which it might be confronted. As an introductory chapter within an extensive trilogy this arrangement has a clear purpose, although the density of independent events remains restricted when viewed as a self-contained story.

Overall Assessment: A Narrative of Choice Left Open

Chapter [–28] introduces a technologically capable character through an unresolved ethical alternative. Raghav's assistance to a poor family establishes a positive act; Burhbā's concern maintains the openness of the future; Gop Kumar's question mark inscribes uncertainty within the archive itself. The folk song envisages both protection and abuse, while the prose refuses to settle the eventual choice. The chapter offers the capacity for decisive action rather than a final moral judgement. Its place in the long narrative lies in preparing possible future connections, not in presenting their outcome as already achieved.

Critical Section 74 | Original Chapter −27 — Aruni's Construction

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

A Story of Construction: The Continuity of Process Rather Than the Finished Object

The title "Aruni's Construction" might suggest a bridge or embankment presented as a completed, stable object. Yet the prose's actual centre of gravity lies in the care required after construction. Aruni reconstructs an old embankment in a new form, introduces modern forecasting equipment, and faces a flood in which the embankment is tested. Burhbā insists that an object built solidly once does not become eternally secure. The story of construction is consequently not a single closed event, but the beginning of a generational cycle of maintenance. The ending creates an obligation for the future rather than simply celebrating a finished engineering project.

Disaster in Childhood Memory: The Background of Motivation

Aruni retains stories of floods from childhood and remembers Indrani's earlier arrangements for advance warning. The novel does not restage those experiences in detail; the narrator makes them a background to the profession Aruni chooses. Flooding becomes not merely an obstacle, but a narrative source of professional consciousness. Importantly, the chapter does not establish that Aruni directly witnessed the particular disaster described in the earlier episode. Learning from a narrated event and experiencing it personally are different forms of memory. The transmission of remembered experience, rather than solely autobiographical recollection, informs Aruni's approach to engineering.

The Kamala-Balan: An Active Narrative Place, Not Stable Ground

The Kamala-Balan River provides the decisive geography of the episode. Its rising waters, the old earthen embankment, and the recurrence of floods compel observation, planning, and nighttime vigilance. The river is not a picturesque backdrop; its changing behaviour motivates human action. Nevertheless the prose does not supply measurements of flow, numerical water levels, or a technical plan of the embankment. The relation between people and river is rendered in literary form rather than as a hydrological specification. The river remains a changing, testing presence within the narrative world.

The Illusion of "Permanent" Construction and the Reply to It

Aruni wishes to build a bridge or embankment "that will never break." This is an expression of desire, not a demonstrated accomplishment. Burhbā immediately counters it with the possibility that even strong construction will deteriorate without attention. The song's praise of durability and the prose's caution about maintenance modify one another, saving the chapter from an unqualified faith in technical progress. That the improved embankment survives one particular flood proves its performance in that particular trial; it does not establish its invulnerability to every future disaster.

Older Knowledge Embodied in Elders and Women

The new embankment is not described as the exclusive achievement of engineering learned in a city. Elders know the ways of the river, while women have long observed the rise of its waters. Recognising this communal knowledge is a significant narrative gesture. Yet the text does not show a particular woman directing a design decision or an individual elder's advice altering a construction plan. Community expertise is acknowledged, while personal names and the authority visible in decisions remain more concentrated around Aruni. The difference between recognised knowledge and dramatised participation deserves critical attention.

Instruments and Local Experience: Combination Rather Than Replacement

The improved embankment and new forecasting apparatus are brought into relation with the villagers' inherited ability to interpret the river. The story does not adopt the simplistic formula of discarding the old whenever a new device arrives. The song likewise refuses to dismiss elders' knowledge as inferior to machinery. What remains less developed is the practical method for checking inherited observations against measurements or assessing the instruments' limitations. At the literary level, the combination sustains communal continuity; the novel does not take on the task of proving the engineering success of a fully specified integrated system.

The Night Watch: Community Made Visible in Action

A major flood arrives one year. Villagers keep watch upon the embankment throughout the night, carrying lamps, and the embankment holds. This is the chapter's most clearly dramatised episode, moving from advice to collective action. The survival of the embankment is explicitly narrated; the precise engineering contribution made by the

night watch is not. The dramatic effect is nonetheless important: success does not belong solely to inert stone, but also to people remaining bodily present and alert. Neither a breach nor deaths caused by the flood are described during this particular test.

The Return of Indrani's Tradition Across Generations

The chapter recalls the earlier tradition of flood warnings associated with Indrani, when signals and communal evacuation formed part of the village's preparedness. In Aruni's period, the means of response include instrument-assisted forecasting and more durable construction. The story does not reproduce an identical event. Instead, historical change alters the tools available for confronting a recurring danger. In this intergenerational recurrence the flood narrative is cyclical but also developmental. The natural threat survives; responses become more varied and, potentially, more effective.

The Bridge in the Song Versus the Embankment in the Narrated Event

The song and Aruni's conversation mention both bridges and embankments. The principal action, however, specifically describes improving the village's old embankment and observing its performance during a flood. No separate bridge over a named river is depicted being completed and surviving that same event. Consequently, to claim that Aruni built a particular bridge which was tested in the flood would exceed the textual evidence. "Bridge" belongs to the broader professional category and to the discussion of lifelong care; the embankment is the chapter's concrete object of action.

The Tension Between the Language of Protection and Victory

When the embankment holds, the narrator casts the outcome as a victory. Aruni understands it not as a victory of stone alone, but as one involving the hands of people who remained awake all night. "Victory" celebrates a successful moment; "maintenance" points towards future precautions. The resolution thus leaves the problem in place rather than proclaiming the conquest of nature. Another flood may come, and another test may be required. Durability is imagined as a relationship sustained through labour, not a fact independent of events.

The Formation of a Professional Character

Aruni's education, decisions, dialogue, and eventual resolve to attach a maintenance plan to every construction make him a character who applies his learning in his profession. Burhbā's moral advice becomes a practical rule of work. This is more specific than portraying Aruni merely as

someone who speaks correctly about technology. The prose does not identify the office responsible, the budget, the maintenance committee, or the legal arrangements by which these future duties will be enforced. His constructive professionalism is established through a value-sensitive plan, rather than through an entire administrative scheme.

The Time of Responsibility: A Future-Oriented Final Sentence

At the end, Aruni resolves that every bridge and embankment should have a plan identifying who will care for it and who will preserve its accounts. The promise specifies future agents and repeated obligations. Thus an apparently completed construction episode opens onto a new administrative beginning. The pattern corresponds to the larger novel's ethics of witnessing: just as names are not preserved without recurring acts of remembrance, physical structures cannot remain secure without recurrent care. This correspondence between cultural memory and material maintenance is one of the chapter's important formal achievements.

Dialogue Beneath the Peepal: From Education to Implementation

The chapter moves through Aruni's desire for an unbreakable structure, Burhbā's caution that maintenance is essential, a subsequent flood which tests the embankment, and Aruni's long-term plan. Dialogue is therefore not simply an interruption of action by a moral lesson; it contributes to the formation of a later decision. The chronological qualification is necessary: the initial reconstruction appears to have been undertaken before the dialogue. Burhbā's words cannot be identified as its original cause. Their role is rather to develop Aruni's maturity after construction and before he commits himself to an ongoing system of care.

The Visibility and Invisibility of Communal Labour

The people of the village appear together during the nighttime watch, but those who remain awake are not individually named. Aruni receives the central professional role, Burhbā the interpretive one, and the villagers form a collective background of embodied labour. This produces a strong image of solidarity. Its limitation is that unequal burdens of maintenance, women's work, and caste-differentiated responsibilities are not narrated in detail. Criticism should recognise the absence without erasing the labour of the group by treating the entire result as Aruni's solitary accomplishment.

Recurring Disaster Time and the Character's Response

The arrival of a major flood “one year” is a particular occurrence. Aruni's decision to arrange maintenance “for every construction,” on the other

hand, concerns repeated future conduct. He is therefore characterised less as the victorious hero of a single flood than as a professional assuming continuing responsibility. The discourse leaps from one scene to a prospective pattern across his working life. In this enlargement of time, immediate achievement and slow discipline appear equally necessary. The chapter becomes a story of an enduring process rather than a permanently finished event.

Overall Assessment: A Narrative That Builds the Future of the Embankment

The chapter's strongest centre is not the miracle of permanent stone but the responsibility to maintain what has been built. Indrani's earlier warnings, elders' and women's river knowledge, new instruments, and the communal night watch form a connected narrative. Survival in one flood is a concrete result, while future invulnerability remains unproven. Aruni translates Burhbā's teaching into professional judgement. In this way the older principle of protecting names is extended to the care of soil, water, bridges, and embankments. The ending defines success as a duty still to be performed.

Critical Section 75 | Original Chapter −26 — Devika's Song

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

History Preserved in Sound: Another Form of Writing

Devika begins recording the village's old folk songs with a machine. Rather than converting an oral tradition solely into written words, she attempts to retain the presence of the voice as sound. Village memory has previously travelled through registers, letters, official papers, and letters typed on a computer. Here vocal inflection, melody, and the body of a singing voice become the objects of preservation. A change in medium also changes the experience of time: a song once dependent on the living presence of its performer and listeners can now be heard again. The story broadens the archive from named words to the acoustic performance of remembering.

The Inheritance of Mohan's Melodic Tradition

At the beginning, Devika is presented as taking forward the melodic tradition associated with Mohan. This is an inheritance of sound through which a person from an earlier era informs the work of a later singer and collector. The text does not assert that every one of Mohan's melodies has been completely transmitted to Devika, or that she records Mohan alone. Her material includes songs associated with Hulasa, Jivanti, Gangesh, floods, birth celebrations, songs of parting, and famine refrains. What begins as continuity within one melodic tradition expands into a wider plurality of village song and recollection. The inheritance is extensive without being a claim of total musical recovery.

Original Voices and New Tunes: Two Parallel Texts

Devika records the elderly women's singing as faithfully as she can and later arranges the same songs in new tunes for younger listeners. These activities create two distinguishable forms of transmission: documentation of a source performance and an adapted presentation. The distinction matters. Were the newly arranged tune treated as the only authentic original, the distinct voices of the older singers would be lost in the act of preservation. The prose allows both forms to coexist. It does not, however, provide a numbered recording catalogue, a full version history, or detailed documentation of every musical variant. The two practices are clear, their archival method less fully described.

Fields, Water-Drawing Places, and Embankments: The Songs' Earlier Settings

The prose recalls embankments, places where water was drawn, and threshing yards as locations of communal singing. There, a song belonged to social labour, gathered bodies, and the rhythm of seasons. Recording detaches a performance from its particular occasion and makes it a repeatable sonic object. This offers access to future listeners while potentially diminishing the immediacy of the activity in which the song once lived. The narrator does not turn that tension into an extended debate, but the naming of older performance spaces alongside the machine makes it visible. Recording is not a simple substitute for situated communal practice.

Elderly Women: The Actual Sources of Knowledge

Devika sits with elderly women and listens to songs at risk of disappearing. This recognition of their authority is important because so much of the village's long history has been articulated through Burhbā's exceptional memory. Here women themselves hold, perform, and sustain the traditions of singing. Yet most of their individual names are omitted; the "oldest woman" remains an unidentified speaker. Thus recording may preserve the particularity of a singing voice even where the narrative's naming system leaves the singer's biography comparatively indistinct. The contrast between acoustic preservation and personal anonymity is a legitimate object of criticism.

The Final Famine Refrain: A Meeting Point in Time

One very old woman remembers a famine refrain that nobody else any longer knows. Devika records her trembling voice; only a few days later the woman dies. A multi-century concern with memory is compressed into this brief interval between the last available performance and death. Recording catches a moment in which history is on the verge of becoming inaccessible. The story supplies neither the woman's name and exact age nor the year of the famine. Its particularity lies in the final availability of her living sound. The sharp contrast between the anonymous singer and the surviving melody supplies the episode's emotional intensity.

"Living Again": A Metaphor Reconsidered

The song describes Hulasa as "living again" when an old melody returns in a new voice. This revival is figurative: a repeated name and tune can create the experience of an absent person's emotional presence. The prose does not depict the literal bodily resurrection of the dead. This distinction matters even in the novel's magical and memorial world. The power of the

poetic phrase is not contingent on its becoming an event of physical return. Song revives a connection and a form of awareness rather than restoring the person whose loss was remembered.

The Sound Archive and the Variability of Oral Tradition

A folk song is more than a fixed sequence of words. Performance may alter with voice, occasion, place, and listener. Devika records one rendition and later creates another, preserving at least the possibility that oral tradition remains open to change. The recording of a performance "exactly" is not the same as declaring that it represents the single authoritative form of every version ever sung. The claim of faithfulness refers to an identifiable rendition, not to the totality of a living cultural practice. This distinction is central to the chapter's consideration of acoustic documentation.

The Work of the Machine and the Authority of the Voice

Devika operates the recording apparatus, but obtains the songs from the elderly women. Technical proficiency therefore does not automatically convey sole authority over what is being recorded. The narrative foregrounds Devika's dedication while acknowledging the voices from which her material comes. The relationship is best understood as one in which disciplined listening precedes adaptation and dissemination. Questions about the singers' consent, credit, ownership, and reuse are relevant to such an undertaking, yet the chapter does not stage a full conversation about them. A critical reading may identify their absence but cannot invent agreements or disputes that are not narrated.

From Listeners to Pupils: Transmission as an Institution

Devika establishes a music division at the Coconut-Leaf School, where children learn to use their voices alongside learning letters. The village's shared songs enter a regular educational setting. The repetition of folk performance thus becomes connected to the organised repetition of lessons. Songs formerly heard in threshing yards and at water-drawing places acquire an additional route to survival through teaching. This is the significant final change of state: collection grows into distribution. The text does not imply that schooling replaces all informal singing, but demonstrates how a village institution can take responsibility for its continuation.

Song Before Letters: A Reversal of Educational Priority

At the school, a child learns an old song before learning the alphabet. This precise ordering is more than a curriculum detail. It makes oral memory prior to the written instruments through which history will later be preserved. The sound of a community precedes the formal ability to record

its words. The episode does not specify how consistently this rule is applied, who teaches each lesson, which songs are selected, or how they are assessed. The event is a symbolic adjustment of educational priority rather than a detailed school timetable.

Many Names Within Song: From Hulasa to the Famine

Devika gathers songs associated with Hulasa, Jivanti, Gangesh, and other remembered persons and events. Their recurrence evokes different periods and social experiences within a brief sequence of names. Each song is not expanded into a self-contained biography; instead the songs form a network of collective remembrance. The chapter does not identify which particular melody was altered in which fashion. The series of names performs a representative rather than exhaustive function. Through it a short episode causes the long trilogy to resonate again, depending upon the reader's recognition of the earlier stories.

The Central Sensory Scene: A Trembling Voice

Among several compressed accounts of Devika's work, the most powerful sensory detail is the trembling voice of the elderly woman. The narrator does not reproduce all the words of her song but preserves an embodied quality of its performance: vocal tremor. That minimal sound-image communicates the proximity of death and the singularity of the singer's presence. Written prose cannot itself make the historical recording audible; it can evoke how fragile the sound was and why preserving it mattered. The difference between a literary description of sound and the sound that the recording might actually contain is part of the episode's aesthetic structure.

The Organisation of Time: Collection, Death, Institution

The action follows three stages: songs are collected over time, the voice of an elderly singer is recorded shortly before her death, and a music division is established at the school. Individual loss becomes a motivation for communal institution-building. The death does not supply a final full stop; it makes the urgency of collection tangible. Yet the assertion that the voice has been saved does not guarantee the recording's eternal safety, uninterrupted future availability, or the survival of every copy. The chapter's hope depends upon future listeners and social institutions as much as upon the machine.

The Relation to Earlier Criticism of Song

Mohan's melodic inheritance is explicitly connected to Devika's work, although their narrative settings differ. Mohan's songs of grief emerged in relation to personal loss and its communal remembrance. Devika's activity

is a broader process of collecting, recording, adapting, and teaching folk music. The current chapter does not repeat every instrumental inconsistency or particular emotional event of the earlier musical episodes; new instruments appear chiefly as means of renewed performance. It would therefore be mistaken to equate all musical episodes merely because they share the language of memory. Their social functions have developed across generations.

Overall Assessment: The Oral Narrative Retains Its Voice

Chapter [–26] extends the preservation of names towards the preservation of voices. Devika's recordings, the elderly women's living performances, the adaptation of old tunes, and the school's music programme form a cycle of cultural transmission. The singer's death provides the principal emotional test. To "live again" belongs to the figurative language of the song, whereas recording and teaching are actual narrative acts. The claim of permanence remains a hope. What the story concretely achieves is the creation of an opportunity for a later generation to hear sounds that might otherwise have disappeared.

Critical Section 76 | Original Chapter −25 — Meera's Privacy

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

From Memory to Consent: A Change in the Meaning of "Name"

Throughout the long novel, "preserving names" has served as a defence against death and oblivion. Meera's chapter introduces a necessary qualification to that formula: preserving somebody's name does not authorise the publication of information about them without permission. The opening proverb, "The story belongs to the person whose permission it requires," raises the question of ownership in narration itself. The community's interest in remembering and the individual's power to control the use of a personal story are not identical. This new tension makes the older ideal of preserving names ethically more demanding and more precise.

Meera: Heir to the Night Assembly and an Independent Agent

Meera is an educated young woman who works on digital privacy and women's safety. She carries forward the tradition of Sapnā's digital night assembly by adding the dimension of legal assistance. The relationship is not necessarily one of direct blood descent; it is a succession of social function. In Sapnā's chapter, speaking collectively reduced isolation and fear. In Meera's episode, recourse to legal support is added to that inherited practice. This development gives Meera the agency of someone who changes a community institution, rather than simply listening to Burhbā's familiar advice.

The Incident Involving an Unnamed Young Woman: Visibility Without a Personal Name

An unnamed young woman has her photograph stolen and used in an attempt to disgrace her. She comes to the digital night assembly, and Meera arranges legal help. The narrative does not disclose the young woman's name, the photograph, or the details of her private circumstances. In a chapter concerned with privacy, this restraint may itself have significance and should not be dismissed automatically as a failing. At the same time, anonymity leaves her individual reflections and particular decisions less audible. The story concentrates upon the injury she has faced and the help made available to her, while limiting the reader's access to her distinct biography.

The Photograph: From a Representation of the Person to an Object of Injury

The photograph is not an aesthetic keepsake or an innocent means of remembrance. It becomes an instrument through which another person attempts public humiliation without consent. The theft of an image and the threat of carrying a person's name into the market expose an unsafe separation between a human being and a reproducible representation of that person. Control over the circulating image can pass into unfamiliar hands. The digital crisis is thus a question of power over representation, not merely of a defective or dangerous screen. The prose, however, does not specify where the photograph was posted or whether it was altered, and no such episode should be manufactured.

"I Am Not a Specimen": The Song's Claim to Self-Ownership

The song gives a first-person expression of ownership over one's own story: the speaking woman refuses to be treated as a specimen. Meera's prose dialogue raises the structure of rights and permission, but not every line of the song is a literal quotation from an event. "Specimen" opposes the reduction of a person to an object of research, publicity, data collection, or rumour before her wishes have been considered. The song turns that principle into a memorable collective statement. Its poetic declaration must not be mistaken for a particular statutory clause or an exact legal judgement reported by the narrative.

Public Speech and Privacy: A Possible Conflict

The digital night assembly gives an injured woman collective listeners and potentially brings a hidden wrongdoer into the light. Privacy, however, also demands that details of her image and experience not be disclosed beyond her choice. The chapter therefore combines two aspirations: overcoming enforced silence and restoring control over personal representation. How far public solidarity respects the woman's own decision is an essential critical question. The prose refers to legal assistance but does not set out detailed rules for confidentiality or consent within the gathering. The ideal is clearly articulated; the institutional mechanism for applying it is incompletely described.

The Formal Difference from Sapnā's Earlier Chapter

In "The Screen's First Shadow," a threatened young woman found support for speaking in the night assembly. The present chapter concerns an incident involving a stolen photograph, legal assistance, and a more explicit account of privacy rights. No evidence identifies the unnamed women in the two chapters as one continuous biographical character. The

similarity of their situations represents the recurrence of a social problem rather than the continuity of an individual life. The meaningful development is the refinement of a communal institution's response: from collective listening to the addition of legal and informational protection.

Burhbā's Statement: A Revision of the Earlier Formula

Burhbā says that whereas the old crocodile consumed bodies but could not devour names, the new crocodile seeks to devour both names and dignity. This revises a formula that has organised the novel's world of remembrance. The older confidence that names could always be secured faces a new challenge in the digital circulation of identity and image. Burhbā is therefore not merely an unchanging teacher repeating timeless truths; the meaning of his metaphor evolves in response to new social circumstances. The revision makes historical change visible within the continuity of his character.

Remembering Sulochana and Padma

Burhbā associates Meera with the earlier struggles of Sulochana and Padma. Their names form a long intergenerational sequence concerning women's dignity and justice. These invocations are interpretive acts of remembrance; they do not establish that the earlier women lived under identical legal conditions or faced precisely the same offences. Modern questions of digital privacy are illuminated by older experiences of humiliation and resistance, but historical distinctions remain necessary. The novel's intertextual continuity works through comparison, not a denial that different periods generate different forms of injury.

The Law in the Story: A Scene of Help, Not a Completed Judgement

Meera obtains legal assistance and helps bring the previously hidden wrongdoing into public view. This is a genuine action within the episode. It does not necessarily mean that the offender was arrested or convicted, that compensation was awarded, or that all copies of the image were removed from a platform. “Bringing into the light” describes social disclosure and intervention, not a fully narrated legal process. Keeping the distinction makes it possible to respect the hopeful direction of the chapter without transforming incomplete institutional action into a verdict the prose does not contain.

Narrative Focalisation: Meera Speaks More Than the Victim

Meera and Burhbā receive the conceptual dialogue through which the reader encounters privacy and permission. The injured woman is described in terms of the event she has suffered and the dignity she regains, but her own testimony is not reproduced at length. This unequal distribution of

speech centres female leadership while granting the victim comparatively limited narrative language. In a chapter organised around the principle that one's story requires one's consent, the narration thereby invites an internal question: through whose voice is the person's experience told? This is an observation about represented speech, not a claim that an additional episode of silencing must have occurred.

The Mythic Crocodile: From Flesh to Data

The old aquatic crocodile returns as an image of a force that consumes women's images, personal information, and honour. This metaphor makes a new technical threat intelligible within the language of the village's older water-borne fears. It does not assert that biological crocodiles cause cybercrime. The novel uses familiar cultural imagery to translate a new experience for its narrative community. Yet labelling every digital injury a single kind of crocodile may conceal important distinctions between methods and consequences. The specific theft of an image must therefore remain visible alongside the figurative continuity.

The Reader's Ethical Position: Consent Rather Than Curiosity

Crime narratives often provoke curiosity about the offender, the image taken, and the victim's complete private history. The chapter's principle requires a different discipline: a wish to know is not automatically a right to be told. The photograph is not reproduced and the victim's identity remains restricted. This restraint may be read as meaningful within the relationship between the narrative and its reader. Were a critic to fill these gaps with invented intimate details, the criticism would contradict the very subject it professes to analyse. Attention to limits is not an evasion of interpretation but a component of it.

From Individual Help to Institutional Instruction

At the end, Meera teaches women and young girls about digital security, means of challenging abuse, and places from which legal help may be sought. Assistance in one incident becomes an ongoing programme of collective instruction. This develops the earlier night assembly, turning individual suffering into a motive for regular vigilance and practical knowledge. The concluding sentiment that no woman should stand alone is an expression of communal aspiration. It is not empirical proof that every woman in the village is now protected in every possible circumstance.

Narrative Time: A Struggle Begun, Not Concluded

The ending explicitly presents the struggle for privacy as one that has begun rather than ended. One young woman has received assistance, but the larger problem of control over images and personal information

remains. Such an open ending makes Meera's work a continuing responsibility. Legal support, communal solidarity, and personal consent are not represented as institutions that need only be created once; they require repeated application. Within the long novel this incompletion provides a basis for future digital conflicts rather than closing the subject with a simple episode of rescue.

Overall Assessment: Setting a Boundary to the Right to Preserve Names

Chapter [–25] subjects the novel's own memorial project to an ethical question. Names must be remembered, but the person to whom a name and image belong must have a say in their use. Meera advances Sapnā's night assembly by connecting communal help with legal resources. The represented outcome remains limited: a woman is helped, while a complete legal adjudication is not described. The song's declaration of ownership, Burhbā's revised crocodile metaphor, and the continuing struggle for privacy deepen the novel's conception of what the preservation of a name should mean.

Critical Section 77 | Original Chapter −24 — Nishant's Bank

The prehistory · An independent narratological reading grounded in the original novel

A Story of Banking: Language More Than Convenience

After studying banking, Nishant wants accounts, insurance, and credit to become accessible to families in the village. At first the episode looks like a tale of economic development, yet its real emphasis is on understanding the language in which financial services are explained. The old moneylender's account book and the complicated papers of a modern bank may both be unfamiliar to a poor farmer. Inclusion is therefore not merely the number of accounts opened. It requires the ability to understand a document's meaning in one's own language. Through this choice, the novel connects its long narrative of written records with the practical possession of monetary rights.

Nishant as Character: An Interpreter Rather Than Merely an Officer

Nishant's professional education places him in a position of knowledge different from that of the farmer. Burhbā specifically advises him to render the language of banking in the speech of ordinary villagers. His task is a social translation of technical information: the person who understands should not preserve another's dependence, but should make that person capable of asking questions. Nishant consequently becomes a narrative intermediary between a financial institution and village experience rather than simply the institution's representative. The chapter does not name a particular bank, post, or rate of interest; adding these details would exceed the source.

The Old Moneylender: An Echo Across Historical Periods

Nishant has heard stories of debt traps in earlier periods, when poor people lost land, homes, and social standing. The difficult language of the bank might reproduce the underlying inequality of understanding through which the older moneylender exercised power. This comparison is important: a change in institution does not automatically abolish unequal access to knowledge. Yet the current chapter does not describe a particular act of fraud committed by a contemporary bank. That banking could become exploitative in this manner is a conditional warning. Keeping possibility separate from fact is essential to a fair literary-critical reading.

"Selling the Name" in the Song: An Economic Metaphor

The song uses the language of accounts and the sale of names: someone might be said to have "sold" a name within an account. The prose does not show Nishant selling anybody's personal data or a bank account serving as the site of a literal transaction in identities. The proverb evokes commodification and the risks of figures whose significance a person does not understand. Here "name" combines individual identity, documentary standing, and social dignity. If the figurative sale were treated as a specific crime, the episode's principal concern—the inaccessibility of banking language—would be displaced by an event the text has not narrated.

The Elderly Farmer's Scene: From Fear to Trust

An elderly farmer is afraid to place his thumb impression upon an unfamiliar paper. After Nishant explains it plainly, the farmer opens his first account. Later, on receiving his first insurance payment, tears appear in his eyes. Abstract "financial inclusion" becomes a bodily and emotional experience through this sequence. The fear surrounding the thumb impression evokes the danger of commitments whose written conditions are not understood. Yet the text does not say what event triggered the insurance claim or the amount paid. The scene offers an emotionally concrete transformation, not a comprehensive evaluation of a financial scheme.

The Thumb Impression: Literacy and Rights

The farmer's reluctance to mark the document with his thumb is a significant image. In earlier social narratives, signatures and impressions on papers could become instruments of exploitation when controlled by stronger parties. Here Nishant helps diminish that fear by making the terms intelligible before the farmer agrees. The dignity of the individual is not made dependent solely on formal literacy; what matters first is a person's right to understand the undertaking in which he is involved. The chapter does not administer a literacy test or define the farmer's exact educational level. His difficulty concerns the meaning and consequences of written banking terms.

Explanation in Maithili: The Linguistic Right to Understand

Nishant explains financial arrangements in simple Maithili. Narratively, this is more than a celebration of the regional language. It makes the significance of an institutional document accessible to the people whose lives are governed by it. When bank rules remain in unfamiliar official terminology, an account holder may become estranged from the story recorded about his own money. Explanation in Maithili reduces that separation. The act resembles the novel's older project of preserving names:

a person represented in a document should also be able to comprehend what the document claims and demands. The right to understand complements the right to be named.

The Chaupal Becomes a New School of Economics

Nishant sits at the village chaupal and uses illustrations and examples to explain accounts, insurance, and loans. A public place formerly associated with hearing stories becomes a place of financial education. The open communal setting contrasts with the closed office and the intimidating form. Instruction emerging from Burhbā's dialogue beneath the peepal becomes practical teaching at the chaupal. The important spatial change is that an inherited gathering-place acquires a new social function. Tradition does not merely repeat an old ritual; it creates an accessible setting for understanding a changing institutional world.

Not Compromise but Comprehension: The Ethical Centre of the Advice

Burhbā's guiding idea is that injustice often begins when one party understands a transaction and the other does not. The episode does not make banking an unconditional liberator. It requires financial institutions and their interpreters to share knowledge with the people affected by decisions. Assistance becomes meaningful when the beneficiary can make a comprehending choice. Yet Burhbā's statement is a character's broad ethical generalisation, not proof that every injustice has only this one cause. Previous chapters have shown oppression linked to labour, caste, gender, land, and law as well. The chapter selects unequal comprehension as its particular focus.

Self-Reliance Distinguished from Numerical Expansion

Nishant hopes to make financial services available to every family. The elderly farmer's account and insurance payment supply a specific successful example. The narrative does not report that every family has joined, that every loan has been repaid, or that long-term poverty has ended. Its broad closing suggestion that complex banking language need no longer become a means of deception goes beyond the limited number of dramatised instances. Recognising this uneven evidentiary scale does not deny the value of what Nishant does. It defines how much the individual episode demonstrates and how much remains an institutional aspiration.

Accounts and Gop Kumar's Archive

Gop Kumar brings together old registers, maps, and digital documents to preserve collective memory. Nishant renders the meaning of banking documents accessible to ordinary people. Both characters are concerned

with the social power carried by paper, but their purposes differ: one gathers the past, the other helps people exercise present economic rights. The documentary motif thus develops from preserving names to making records understandable. In neither chapter is paper intrinsically just or unjust. Its meaning depends upon access, interpretation, the uses to which it is put, and the people who are allowed to read or question it.

Long-Awaited Justice and Immediate Tears

The elderly farmer's tears give the extended history of economic exploitation a brief compassionate focus. Memories of famine, moneylending, and landlessness find a limited counterpoint in this personal receipt of an insurance payment. It is not a retrospective legal settlement of every earlier injustice; it is one person's experience in the present. Treating the scene as proof of a transformation of the whole rural economy would exceed the prose. Its literary force lies in concentrating a long problem of dignity and financial insecurity into a small, affecting human moment.

The Proportion of Dramatisation to Explanation

Much of the chapter consists of Nishant's intentions and Burhbā's educational dialogue. The old farmer provides the clearest emotional event. This distribution gives the work conceptual clarity but comparatively little developed dramatic conflict. The difficulty of specific forms, rejection of applications, disputes, and appeals are not individually represented. The easy movement towards an affirmative result accelerates narrative pace and reduces some institutional complexity. Nevertheless the farmer's actual change from fear to comprehension prevents the chapter from remaining an entirely abstract moral lesson.

Banking After Meera's Privacy: Another Dimension of Rights

In the preceding chapter, Meera asserts a person's control over the use of images and personal information. Nishant centres the right to understand the meaning of one's financial records. Both episodes examine unequal relations between individuals and institutions in a digital and documentary age. One asks, “Who may use my name?”; the other asks, “How can I understand my account?” Their sequence broadens the novel's treatment of numerical and institutional power from deception by outsiders to opacity within ordinary systems. The text, however, does not present the two characters collaborating in a joint initiative.

The Song and the Prose: From Clear Accounts to Self-Respect

The song warns that accounts must remain clear. The prose translates the warning into a farmer's developing confidence in his right to understand

and use financial services. Numbers, names, and dignity thus meet within one scene. The simplification of banking language creates a social relationship rather than merely adding another account to a register. Its significance exceeds a general announcement that many accounts now exist, because the narration stresses the act of comprehension. The song offers a principle of care; the narrated event offers social translation; the concluding extension proposes ongoing instruction.

Overall Assessment: The Village's Name Within the Language of Banking

Chapter [−24] turns financial inclusion into a narrative of social translation. Nishant learns to explain complex banking language in accessible Maithili, while the elderly farmer's first account and insurance payment give this programme a tangible result. The memory of old moneylenders warns of the potential misuse of incomprehensible terms, but no specific contemporary bank fraud is narrated. A broad claim of educational success is supported by only a limited dramatic example. In the history of the long novel, names, written accounts, and economic dignity acquire a new relationship: to protect a person's name is also to let that person understand the records written in it.

Critical Section 78 | Original Chapter −23 — Nand's Birth

The prehistory · A source-grounded narratological reading of the original novel

Birth as the Establishment of Narrative Expectation Rather Than an Event Alone

A son named Nand is born in Aruni's household. At the level of external incident, this is an ordinary family celebration: a sohar is sung, jaggery is distributed, there is dancing and singing, and the father takes the newborn in his arms. Yet the narrator presents the child's arrival from the outset as the coming of someone whose life will become a "beginning" for the story that follows. The present scene is therefore read under the expectation of events still to occur. That expectation gives exceptional narrative reach to an episode with little immediate action: the narrated event is small, but its possible consequences open into an extensive future.

The Song's "Final Witness" and the Prose's Uncertain Future

The folk song describes Nand as the "final witness," in language that sounds almost conclusive. In the main prose, however, Burhbā again admits that he does not know what has been written into the child's life. These utterances do not have the same evidentiary standing. The song offers the assurance of communal hope; the dialogue acknowledges that the future remains unknown. A critical reading must not convert the song's celebratory certainty into a result already established by events. The text draws the reader toward the future while deliberately reserving the nature of that future for subsequent chapters. Foreshadowing and suspension work together to produce expectation.

Aruni: From Engineer to Father

Earlier, Aruni built bridges and embankments and planned their long-term maintenance as protection for the village. Here he brings his newborn to the peepal tree and expresses a wish to teach him the village's stories. The meaning of "building" thereby shifts from engineering a structure to educating a child morally. The two forms of work are not wholly separate: preserving a bridge and cultivating a witness both involve responsibility to coming generations. Aruni's initiative is more than a passive hope for Nand's destiny. It is a commitment to teach, even though the chapter does not yet show the actual completion of that education.

The Witness-Tree: Spatial Perspective and the Reader's Experience

The peepal's extraordinary stillness is a sensory sign within the scene. Elderly villagers compare that stillness with their long experience, but the tree itself speaks no intelligible words. Later, its leaves rustle lightly although the wind is quiet. Together, these details lend the place a witness-like presence. It would be unwarranted to declare them proof of a supernatural agency; they can also be understood as poetic devices that join natural description to collective interpretation. The reader encounters both the tree as a material object and the meanings the community places upon it. Their coexistence, rather than an established miraculous cause, shapes the episode.

Burhbā's Steady Gaze and the Unequal Distribution of Knowledge

The villagers infer from Burhbā's unusual concentration that he sees something remarkable in the newborn. Readers receive additional hints through his dialogue, but Nand's eventual role is still not disclosed. Three levels of knowledge are arranged in the same scene: villagers celebrating a birth, observers recognising the elder's altered manner, and Burhbā himself possessing a partial apprehension of the future. The narrator places the reader among these unequal perspectives. This difference in access creates mystery without presenting the events that remain unspecified as events already accomplished. A suggestive look is not the same thing as a fully revealed destiny.

Naming as a Social Act

"Nand" begins as a name given within the family, but the story immediately places it inside the community's system of remembrance. His father carries him to the peepal; Burhbā repeats and holds his name with particular tenderness; villagers remain assembled for a long time. The name is thus not only a means of address: it marks the entrance of a new person into a shared narrative order. That narrative entrance follows the biological event of birth. The infant cannot express a preference or speak for himself. The expectation surrounding him is therefore made primarily through the utterances and actions of adults, an asymmetry that the narrative does not yet resolve.

The Question of an Inheritance Imposed Upon a Newborn

Burhbā's remark that certain names bear the whole story upon their shoulders makes Nand exceptional. It also permits a critical question about the burden of inheritance. The child has not chosen a purpose, yet the community has already attached the weight of a long history to his name. The narrator largely presents this burden as auspicious, but expressions such as "two shoulders" and the "weight of a name" leave room for later

questions about education, choice, and an independent personality. To treat Nand merely as a predetermined replica of an inherited image would prematurely narrow the possibility of conflict and self-definition in his future life.

From Shell-and-Silver to the Newborn: The Extension of Narrative Time

Burhbā connects the present scene with the foundational episode of the shell mistaken for silver. His attention to the infant's tiny hand carries the entire preceding history into this one instant. The directly narrated time is a single night; the time invoked by memory extends across centuries. This striking disproportion produces an epic effect. A brief domestic moment becomes the potential point of departure for an immense historical continuation. The sense of magnitude arises not from multiplying the current actions but from compression and symbolic resonance. One newborn's arrival can be made to carry the echo of many generations without his own life having yet unfolded.

The Sound of the Sohar and the Silence of the Gaze

The song announces the joy of birth, while the prose records the sohar, communal singing, dancing, and the sharing of jaggery. Against this audible celebration stand Burhbā's unwavering look, the still tree, and the father's lengthy sitting beneath it. The juxtaposition of sound and quiet allows celebration and apprehension to inhabit the same scene. If the chapter were only festive, the shadow of the future would disappear; if it were only prophetic, the happiness of a household welcoming a child would be lost. The narrator constructs the emotional texture through the balance of these experiences rather than granting exclusive authority to either of them.

The Repeated Sign of the Leaves

At the beginning not a leaf moves; at the end the leaves rustle gently. This beginning-and-ending correspondence changes the emotional quality of the tree's presence. Stillness can suggest a long vigil, while the slight rustle resembles a welcome. The resemblance must remain a resemblance: the text uses the language of "as though," not an unequivocal report of divine intervention. It leaves room for the reader to connect natural movement with the scene's symbolic significance without mistaking that connection for an independently verified cause. The power of the motif comes from the suggestive interval between physical occurrence and communal meaning.

Ritual Inheritance and Education

Nand does not become the officiant of the naming or witnessing ritual as soon as he is born. He is an infant. Aruni wants him to know the village's history and eventually carry it forward. The chapter alone therefore supplies no grounds for claiming that Nand has already discharged a responsibility. It delineates the possibility of a future witness; the teaching, practice, and decisions that would make such witnessing effective remain to come. Inheritance is not portrayed merely as something transferred automatically, like property. It requires an extended process of social learning through which the next generation can acquire the capacity to act.

Burhbā's Gentle Language: A Pause amid a Harsh History

After an extended succession of floods, famine, injustice, forgotten names, and fraud, Burhbā's voice becomes exceptionally gentle. That shift matters to the narrative's emotional rhythm. The witness so frequently associated with suffering can also see the possibility of new life. His tenderness is not complete confidence in a foretold outcome; it is serious affection touched by the uncertainty of what awaits the child. Historical criticism and hope for the future need not become opposing attitudes. The change of voice permits them to coexist, and it briefly relieves the tragic intensity of the preceding episodes without denying it.

The Absence of Distinct Caste and Class Voices

The narration concentrates on Aruni's household and the village's common rejoicing. It does not develop the particular experiences of the other social groups surrounding the birth. Earlier chapters have given important roles to leatherworkers, landless labourers, and women's assemblies; here the focus narrows to a family event and Burhbā's unusual relationship with the newborn. That selection can appropriately be noted as a limit of narrative focalisation. It does not, however, establish that a fresh incident of exclusion or oppression occurred during the celebration. Such an event would have to be supplied by the text, not invented to fill a critical observation.

Clothing the Present in a Story Yet to Come

An introductory narrative comment suggests that Nand's story will eventually become the beginning of A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles. This concerns the relation between chronological occurrence and the order in which the story is read. An event earlier in the fictional chronology may become a point of beginning in a later phase of narration. Through that anticipatory declaration, the book reflects upon its own construction and complicates the relation between beginning and ending.

Yet the events of that future narrative are not opened here. The present is invested with a prospective literary role, not made identical with a completed future plot.

The Chapter's Overall Outcome

What actually occurs is Nand's birth, Aruni's wish to initiate him into the village's memorial traditions, and Burhbā's sustained and unusual attention. This should not be read as the immediate triumph of a hero, a decisive act of justice, or proof of an irrevocable destiny. The song's voice of completion and the prose's tender uncertainty create an intentionally vacant future. By preserving that vacancy, the episode becomes a bridge within the long novel: the witness tradition of centuries prepares to enter the possible consciousness of a new human life, rather than achieving its ultimate conclusion on the night of his birth.

Critical Section 79 | Original Chapter −22 — Approaching Twelve Hundred Years

The prehistory · A source-grounded narratological reading of the original novel

A Scene of Calculation: Condensing the Epic through Numbers

One evening Gop Kumar is shown bringing generations, names, and events together in a chronology. The spread of centuries is contained within the labour of one person bending over the documents. Many floods, famines, and wars have already appeared in separate narrative sequences; they now enter a single act of calculation. This is a compression of remembrance rather than a fresh enactment of those events. The reader supplies connections between the stories previously encountered and the present reckoning. Thus a short episode achieves the effect of an enormous historical vista through the act of rearranging and counting what the novel has already narrated.

The Decisive Meaning of "Approaching"

The chapter is called "Approaching Twelve Hundred Years," not "Twelve Hundred Years Completed." Gop Kumar says that nearly twelve centuries will soon have passed since the water burial. Burhbā responds conditionally: "if your calculation is correct." These qualifications matter. The chronology is not presented as an exact, independently demonstrated measurement. A critic who announces a fully established age of precisely twelve hundred years would erase the caution written into the dialogue. Attention should fall on the attraction of the round number and on the narrator's decision to leave its accuracy qualified. The gap between approximation and certainty is part of the chapter's narrative intelligence.

A List of Names within Immense Time

Gop Kumar's calculation calls up Hulasa, Jīvanti, Sukhdev, Ratna, Malati, Savitri, and many others. By invoking persons, the list resists the conversion of history into a bare succession of years. Time becomes a domain of lived social experience rather than an abstract duration. Yet the roster is abbreviated; the life of each person is not recounted afresh. Readers must remember earlier chapters if they are to feel the density these names carry upon their return. Enumeration therefore depends upon the reader's accumulated participation in the novel. What is a few words in this scene may recall the complexity of an entire previous life-story.

Burhbā: The Centre of Chronology, but Not the Only Character

Gop Kumar notices that the generations have altered while Burhbā's name remains continuously present. That persistence makes the long chronology imaginable. Burhbā nevertheless redirects attention from his exceptional longevity towards the people whose names have survived, disappeared, or are still being recovered. The narrative tries to place an extraordinary individual continuity in the service of collective remembrance. This prevents the account from becoming simply the biography of a single immortalised hero. Burhbā's central structural role cannot be denied, but it is repeatedly qualified by the weight of the many other lives he remembers and by the gaps in what even he can preserve.

Rearranging History through Gop Kumar's Perspective

The discovery is narrated through Gop Kumar's growing astonishment. He first connects names, then begins to perceive the scale of the accumulated years, and finally reaches a more human understanding of what that vast duration means. There is a dramatic progression in the act of calculation itself. The number is not inserted merely as a prefabricated date. Its significance changes as the character works and reacts. Readers are invited into a compact process of historiography: addition, surprise, conversation, and reinterpretation. Making a chronology thereby becomes a narrated event rather than a list of dates placed outside the story.

Rare Laughter: The Emotional Rhythm of Time

Burhbā smiles softly when he hears the calculation. Villagers regard this laughter as rare and unforgettable. A witness marked by the grief of many ages has, momentarily, a lighter response to the burden of history. His amusement at the roundness of the number is brief; he soon returns to the names that matter more deeply. The alternation creates an emotional rhythm in which delight lasts a moment and responsibility extends much longer. The scene humanises extraordinary longevity without trivialising the floods, deaths, and losses embedded within it. A small laugh offers relief, not the completion of remembrance.

The Round Number and the Incompleteness of the Story

"Twelve hundred" is an easily retained, rounded figure. Burhbā understands that people may come to remember him through it, but insists that a number cannot complete a story. The remark is also an implicit reflection upon the dimensions of the novel itself. Neither an impressive total of years nor a large number of chapters can adequately determine a work's meaning. Numbers may provide access to the history, but the experiences of countless people lie within it. The contrast between

count and narrative warns against losing particular lives under an apparently comprehensive measure of duration.

Names Preserved and Names Lost: The Boundary of Completeness

Burhbā distinguishes names that have been preserved, names that have vanished, and names still in the process of being recovered. This threefold division gives the ethics of memory a narrative dimension of incompleteness. Were every name already secured, there would be no further need to search and collect. The lost names disclose vacant places in the story, some of which future inquiry may possibly fill. Gop Kumar's digital collection is part of that effort. The present chapter does not announce that all missing names have been found, and its own vocabulary of preservation requires the gaps to remain visible.

Pluralities of Time: One Scene, Many Ages

Through Gop Kumar's reckoning, the reader sees that the water burial, the shell-and-silver incident, famines, floods, wars, and epidemics belong to distinct social periods. As they are gathered within a single evening, historical time acquires the appearance of one extended current. But the song resists excessive compression by saying that it did not all pass "in a single breath." The prose gathers complicated experience into a number; the song recalls its long and difficult unfolding. This tension gives the chapter more than chronological information. It stages the conflict between the convenience of historical synthesis and the irreducible duration of human suffering.

The Prehistory and a Possible Story to Come

The narrator suggests that the nearly twelve-hundred-year figure may later be repeated in another language or by another generation, perhaps becoming something like a title. This is a projection of future reading, not an event already performed by the villagers. The narrative imagines its prospective audience and reflects upon the ways a history may be named or retold. An occurrence and the later act of naming that occurrence belong to different narrative levels. In this self-referential moment, the work hints that its meaning may open again in another telling, even after the chronology appears to have gathered everything onto Gop Kumar's table.

Ritual Recurrence and the Difference Made by Calculation

Earlier acts of remembrance occurred through songs, kabaddi, assemblies under the peepal, and written registers. Gop Kumar now converts their continuous practices into an ordered chronology. Communal performance and integrated historical reckoning do not convey information in identical ways. A song carries the recurrence of experience; an archive

attempts to map relations among events. The present act does not abolish either form. Instead, it provides another way of understanding the long practice, increasing the significance of earlier rituals by showing how they may be connected across time. Calculation becomes a supplement to lived remembrance, not its replacement.

Burhbā's Immortality: A Narrative Convention, Not a Historical Claim

The presence of a witness over nearly twelve centuries belongs to the imaginative architecture of the fiction. Presenting that duration as externally verified historical evidence would confuse the status of the narrative. The novel uses Burhbā's extraordinary continuity as a bodily centre for collective memory and as a bridge among events otherwise separated by generations. Narratological criticism asks how this convention makes an extended story coherent. It does not need to prove the literal age of a timeless being. The achievement is structural and symbolic: the unusual protagonist enables many scattered histories to be perceived as parts of a continuous communal narrative.

The Song's Catalogue of Calamities and the Prose's Catalogue of Names

The song recurs to floods, famine, war, and epidemics, while the prose brings successive named figures into Gop Kumar's computation. Both create continuity through repetition, but their emotional functions differ. The song arranges history as a rhythm of collective suffering and renewed effort; the prose arranges it through persons and dates. One calls forth the pattern of survival, the other the plurality of lives through which that survival has been enacted. Their joint effect depends on reading these catalogues in relation without treating them as equivalents. A community's history is neither an inventory of catastrophes alone nor a roster abstracted from their consequences.

A Future Title as a Signal to the Reader

The closing possibility of repeating the number “in another language” introduces no clearly identified new character or event. It establishes an intertextual expectation. A scholarly reading should not turn the hint into an exact publication announcement, a settled translation project, or an inevitable future volume. The evidence supports an anticipation, nothing more definite. Its literary function is to suggest that the counted past remains open to other readings. The history temporarily condensed into a chronology may unfold again when another audience or narrative language encounters it.

Overall Narratological Assessment

Chapter [–22] introduces no new catastrophe. Instead, it gives the catastrophes already narrated a new perspective through calculation. Gop Kumar's work captures historical extent; Burhbā's response delineates what counting cannot capture. Words such as "nearly" and "if" distinguish numerical approximation from certainty. The chapter's merit lies in keeping the enormity of time from becoming a hollow celebration of scale: within its estimate remain Hulasa, Ratna, Sukhdev, and innumerable others whose names demand attention. Quantification becomes meaningful precisely when it acknowledges the limits imposed by incomplete remembrance.

Critical Section 80 | Original Chapter −21 — Ananya's Question

The prehistory · A source-grounded narratological reading of the original novel

A Change of Scene: From Immense History to the Classroom

In Chapter [−22], Gop Kumar arranged centuries within a chronology; the present chapter brings the narrative into a modern classroom. Vast historical time is condensed into the relation between teacher and pupils. Ananya teaches in the modern branch of the Coconut-Leaf School, linking a long-established institution of remembrance with a new educational practice. The school is not an incidental background. It is the place in which the accumulated experience of earlier generations begins to pass into the perspective of children. In this setting, one apparently small question becomes a decisive narrative development in place of an enormous historical event.

From Memorised Answers to Active Questions

Children who ask questions receive praise in Ananya's classroom, and no question is condemned as foolish. This educational method creates room for uncertainty within the novel. Burhbā has long functioned as an interpreter of crises; here the teacher allows children to originate their own questions. Knowledge is no longer merely an inheritance of prepared answers. It becomes a practice through which new meanings may be made. For criticism, the central issue is the enlargement of the right to ask, the changing relation between speaker and listener, and the emergence of new narrative agency through dialogue—not the independent verification of an abstract philosophical proposition.

Nand's Question: The Character's First Direct Sign

In Chapter [−23], Nand was a newborn whose anticipated importance existed in the words of adults. He now raises his hand and asks a question of his own. This modest action is the first concrete narrative performance of his personality. Burhbā's premonition no longer supplies the sole means of identifying him; in the classroom Nand presents himself through his words. The birth scene promised that his life might matter. The classroom scene begins to show how he thinks. The credibility of his emergence as a protagonist rests more securely upon this active question than upon a destiny stated on his behalf.

Retelling the Shell-and-Silver Episode

Ananya recounts the old story of someone who takes a shell to be silver. Its return is not merely a compressed repetition of the opening narrative. A new teacher, a new audience, and a new question give the older occurrence a different function. What once formed the basis of a story about mistaken identification now becomes material for practising inquiry. The story's recipient has changed, and with that change its work within the narrative also changes. This transformation demonstrates that communal memory need not consist of immovable repetitions; it may become an instrument through which later generations learn to formulate their own responses.

The Teacher's Smile: A Small but Definite Outcome

Nand asks whether the person might have escaped deception by first asking if the apparent silver was really silver. Ananya smiles. No extended lecture is needed for the scene to establish the intellectual and ethical value of questioning. The smile registers approval, not the defeat of a criminal in an actual case. The chapter does not describe Nand unmasking a fraud or solving a future digital problem. Rather, his possible later courage begins symbolically in the everyday skill of asking before accepting an appearance. A small classroom exchange is given the significance of a beginning, while the test of its practical consequences remains to come.

The Limits of Access to the Child's Inner Life

The narrator calls Nand the child who asks the most questions, but does not provide a complete account of his internal reasoning. His intellectual disposition becomes visible through his behaviour and one reported question. Readers infer a pattern of thought from that action. Other pupils remain unnamed, and their individual questions do not receive comparable space. The selection foregrounds Nand but reduces the potentially polyphonic classroom to its significance for him. This is a limit of focalisation, not permission to invent the reactions or private histories of the children whose voices are not individually recorded.

Ananya's Institutional Authority

Ananya does more than repeat Burhbā's lessons. She changes school practice by giving questions priority over rote learning. The classroom develops its own rule: children are permitted to speak and inquire. Elders initially find the change surprising and later recognise its worth. Through this sequence, the teacher acquires a distinctive social position. Burhbā's approval lends her work recognition, but the basis of her agency is already visible in the school scene. Treating her as nothing more than a translator of an older man's wisdom would neglect the independent practical decisions that shape the children's learning environment.

The Song's Dome and the Material Reality of the Scene

The folk song imagines a small question cracking a great dome. That dome symbolises an established illusion or a body of unexamined assumptions. No actual dome collapses in the classroom. The song speaks in a triumphant, generalised register; the prose depicts a particular exchange between teacher and pupil. The contrast allows questioning to appear simultaneously as a modest real action and as an expansive poetic possibility. Recasting the metaphor as literal damage to a school building, or as a specific political occurrence, would import an event absent from the source and obscure the relation between song and narrated scene.

Repeated Inquiry and the Movement of Narrative Time

Ananya's teaching is described as a continuing daily practice rather than one isolated occurrence. Against the summary of recurring questions, the narrator singles out the day on which Nand asks his particular question. The relation between repetition and scene creates meaning: the long habit helps form character, while one quoted utterance provides its perceptible example. Years of possible instruction are concentrated into a brief narrative interval. Readers grasp something of Nand's developing disposition without receiving a complete record of the school's pedagogy or every lesson conducted during those years.

Connection with the Earlier Digital Frauds

Chapters [−38], [−36], and [−35] have already introduced misinformation, financial deception, and fraudulent recruitment. Against that narrative history, Ananya's practice of questioning acquires a prospective social importance. But Nand does not solve an online crime in the present classroom chapter. The story first establishes a disposition and leaves its possible application to a later phase. It thus creates an interval between acquiring a capacity and demonstrating an achievement. Earlier dangers deepen the reader's interest in the scene without making a specific future victory certain or allowing a critic to narrate it in advance.

Peepal Tree and School: Two Places of Learning

Burhbā speaks with Ananya beneath the peepal, while Nand asks his question in the school. The two locations carry distinct institutional meanings. The peepal is associated with long communal memory and ritual dialogue; the school offers formal exercises in which children actively question received accounts. Ananya participates in both, creating a passage between them. Tradition and modern teaching are not made enemies, yet the school's reforms should not be reduced to an unchanged continuation of the old peepal assemblies. The places differ even as knowledge moves between them.

Gangesh's Presence as Narrative Memory, Not a New Scene

Gangesh's name appears in the lesson, song, and Burhbā's discussion. The historical figure is not physically present as an acting character in this modern classroom. His earlier narrative is reactivated through remembered words and educational practice. In this way the novel joins centuries within a present lesson. The critic's principal task here is to understand how a remembered name enters a child's capacity to question. The chapter does not require a separate technical examination of a philosophical system that has not been staged as an independent event in the scene.

The Function of the Closing Prediction

The final statement anticipates that Nand's habit of questioning will eventually prove useful against a "crocodile" that can be defeated by questions. It is a long-range signal of what his education might mean. Which crocodile, what conflict, what procedure, and what outcome remain uncertain. The narrator makes readers alert to a future danger without describing its resolution. Such anticipation keeps expectation active across chapters, but it must remain distinct from an event that has already taken place. The prophecy concerns the possible use of acquired habits, not a completed struggle.

The Selectivity of a Story of Successful Education

Ananya's questioning method receives positive treatment; rote teaching supplies its principal contrast. No pupil's sustained resistance, lack of school resources, or failed teaching experiment appears in the scene. The choice makes the teacher's achievement legible but restricts the presentation of institutional complexity. Critical fidelity requires recognising this idealised selection without manufacturing classroom conflicts to compensate for it. The depicted teaching moment is limited but meaningful, and its narrative significance comes chiefly from the formative role it plays in Nand's ongoing story.

Overall Assessment: The Birth of the Question

"Ananya's Question" is, in a critical metaphor, the story of Nand's second birth: first he was born physically, now a questioning outlook begins to take observable form. The phrase is an interpretive figure, not a second literal birth in the novel. The marked destiny of the newborn acquires an active expression in an ordinary school day. Ananya's teaching, one reported question, Burhbā's hope, and the shell-and-silver memory bind the old narrative to potential future crises. The chapter's strength lies less in the answer given than in cultivating the habit by which an answer may later be sought.

Critical Section 81 | Original Chapter −20 — The First Account of the Splash

The prehistory · A source-grounded narratological reading of the original novel

The Bridge Site: The People behind the Technology

After completing his engineering studies, the young Nand goes to work at a bridge-construction site. His father Aruni has already been associated with construction, making the occupational succession clear. Nand's attention, however, moves beyond stones, embankments, and structures towards the lives of labourers: damaged huts, low wages, and unsafe conditions. This change redirects a story centred upon builders towards those whose labour is often less visible within the finished work. The bridge retains its material significance, but the social cost of its construction becomes the episode's primary concern. Technical achievement is brought into contact with the precarious existence of people who make it possible.

The Difference between Hearing an Event and Witnessing It

At the construction site Nand hears that a worker disappeared during the night. The text does not show the disappearance occurring before his eyes, and he tells Burhbā expressly that he has heard the story. The route by which information reaches the protagonist is essential. The worker's name and the reason for his absence are not supplied, nor is his death established. The uncertainty is itself narratively important: a person is absent from the very account in which his presence ought to have been recorded. Criticism must preserve the mediated character of the report rather than convert it into a witnessed killing or a solved mystery.

The Erased Name: Violence through Documentary Absence

The missing worker's name disappears from the contractor's papers. In this detail, the novel's long project of remembering names encounters a new administrative struggle. Bodily absence and documentary absence reinforce each other's danger. When a person is not entered in the register, recognition of labour, an account of wages, and grounds for seeking justice all become more difficult. The episode does not provide the complete chain of an individual contractor's murderous plot or an established documentary conspiracy. Its focus is the significance of erasure as represented in the narrative. The removal of a name becomes a social injury even while the full circumstances of the worker's disappearance remain unknown.

The Title's "Splash": Sound versus Event

The title and song evoke a "first splash" and the image of a name sinking in water. The principal prose concerns bridge construction and information about a missing labourer; it does not narrate a visible physical drowning or a fully described impact upon water. The sound image must therefore be treated as a central metaphor rather than evidence of an actual water accident. The crocodile, pond, and drowning of earlier parts of the novel resonate within the word. Through this symbolic recurrence, the new administrative danger of forgetting a worker becomes linked to older memories of loss by water. Sound connects events without making them physically identical.

The First Practical Consequence of Ananya's Questioning Education

In the previous chapter Ananya encouraged Nand to ask questions. On hearing of the overlooked labourer, he does not simply return to technical work in silence; he brings a question to Burhbā. This is the first substantial movement from a classroom habit into the perception of social inequality. Nand's response is not merely the fulfilment of a prophecy uttered at birth. It develops through an acquired practice of examining appearances and omissions. Yet he has not found the worker's name. His moral awakening and the result of any investigation must remain separate stages. The story depicts the beginning of concern, not its completed resolution.

Burhbā's Memory of Sukhdev: An Ethical Connection across Chapters

When Burhbā hears about the missing worker, he remembers Sukhdev Mahato. This recalled figure associates the present episode with earlier injustice over land and the loss of names from official records. The connection rests upon the disappearance of a disadvantaged person from an authoritative account. It does not establish that Sukhdev and the absent worker experienced identical events, or that the latter belongs to the former's family. The earlier story supplies a language through which present injustice can be recognised. Intertextual memory here acts as a means of interpretation rather than as proof of a biographical identity or a repeated, precisely equivalent crime.

"Find the Name": The Limits of Burhbā's Instruction

Burhbā urges Nand to search for the worker's name and, if he finds it, to preserve it. The conditional "if" matters. It acknowledges that the missing person's name is not immediately available. Nand receives a responsibility to investigate, not an announcement that the inquiry has succeeded. The moment is important in the long novel because remembrance is translated from reverent attention into the active search for someone who has fallen outside the documentary record. The ethical imperative is a beginning,

and its force depends partly on the acknowledgement that success cannot yet be claimed.

Two Bridges: A Material Structure and a Narrative Relation

Burhbā gives the bridge a second meaning: a bridge between the name and the account. One bridge makes possible a physical crossing; the other creates a connection between an overlooked person, remembrance, and the possibility of justice. This is more than a verbal pun, for it enlarges Nand's sense of professional responsibility. Aruni had learned to maintain built structures; Nand begins to assume responsibility for linking workers with the records that recognise them. Both kinds of construction require sustained effort, yet their objects differ. One concerns access across a river; the other concerns visibility within social and administrative life.

The Diary's First Page: The Beginning of a Personal Record

Nand writes Burhbā's old saying—"The crocodile may devour the body, but not the name"—on the first page of his diary. The text adds that he had heard the sentence through his grandmother. Oral transmission across generations now enters a written personal document. Nand does not merely reproduce a familiar maxim; his experience at work gives it a new practical importance. The diary is still at its beginning. One opening page cannot be treated as a complete register of workers or as a finished book of testimony. The act of writing establishes a possible future direction for Nand as a witness.

"An Account of the Splash": A Name Deferred in Time

The narrator anticipates that Nand will later call the diary "An Account of the Splash." This name belongs to a prospective narrative moment. What is shown now is the initial writing of a sentence, not the publication of a complete work or the compilation of a comprehensive list of workers. The deferred naming creates expectation around an object in its earliest stage. A title appears in seed form in the present, while its developed literary or documentary significance is reserved for what follows. Maintaining that time distinction is necessary to avoid turning narrative anticipation into a completed event.

The Ethics of Documentation and the Invisible Character

The worker is not identified by name within this account. That absence is intimately connected with the chapter's subject, because discovering the name becomes Nand's responsibility. Criticism cannot supply a fictional family history, definite cause of death, or court proceeding in order to fill the blank. The available information should be recognised as a deliberate narrative vacancy. It motivates the search and makes the inadequacy of the

official record perceptible. The absence of a name is not a minor missing detail alongside the plot; it helps generate the plot's central ethical problem.

The Song's Stone Bridge and the Engineer of the Prose

The song exhorts its listeners to leave the bridge of stone and build a bridge of names. The prose does not show Nand resigning from engineering. Rather, he returns from the construction site and records an ethical insight. The song intensifies the urgency of preserving names through poetic opposition; the prose attaches a second responsibility to the first. Reading the lyric as a literal decision to abandon his profession would misrepresent the chapter. Nand's significance lies in the possible combination of technical expertise and documentary responsibility, rather than in an exclusive choice of one over the other.

The Arrangement of Scene, Dialogue, and Summary

The narrator briefly sketches the workers' circumstances, reports an incident Nand has heard, follows his return to the village, and gives particular attention to Burhbā's dialogue and the first entry in the diary. The details of the disappearance itself remain largely undramatised. Consequently, the emphasis falls less on a fully developed investigation of labour abuse than on the making of a new witness. The distribution of narrative attention determines the chapter's effect: readers experience the alteration in Nand's concerns more fully than they see the unknown worker's fate. Evaluation should attend to that actual centre of gravity.

Differences between Father and Son as Builders

Aruni's embankment was tested by a flood at night; Nand's ethical understanding is tested by a report that a labourer's name has disappeared. Both occupy fields of construction and environmental intervention, but the threats they confront are not identical. In Aruni's story water tests a physical protective barrier. In Nand's, administrative erasure tests the social relations that ought to support a worker. The contrast shows that technological development alone does not abolish injustice. Witnessing demands a newly adapted form of labour from each generation. The son inherits a vocation while discovering a different kind of structural failure.

Overall Assessment: The Moment When an Engineer Becomes a Witness

Chapter [–20] does not make Nand a solver of every problem. It shows the ethical beginning of his journey. The worker remains unnamed and the outcome unresolved; the future form of the diary has not yet been achieved. Nevertheless, the question learnt in school, the inequality

noticed at the bridge site, and Burhbā's maxim combine to redirect Nand's sense of duty. The "splash" echoes older water-borne losses within a modern administrative disappearance. The bridge of names, set alongside the bridge of stone, prepares the ground for a developing narrative of evidence and remembrance.

Critical Section 82 | Original Chapter −19 — Satyavrat's Decision

The prehistory · A source-grounded narratological reading of the original novel

The Return of a Silence Previously Left Unresolved

In Chapter [−31], Satyavrat Mehta observed suspicious bank transactions but remained silent while recording dates and other details in a private notebook. Now, holding a more senior post, he opens that older notebook again. The return provides a concrete example of the long novel's arrangement of time: a decision deferred in an earlier chapter becomes central many years later. The narrative does not create the present crisis from nothing. It subjects a previously established silence to renewed examination under changed circumstances. Without recalling the earlier chapter, the full significance of the hesitation and the later commitment would be difficult to discern.

From Scattered Points to a Picture: Reorganising Information

The notebook contains separate entries for dates, accounts, and amounts. Viewed together, they begin to reveal a pattern of transactions extending beyond any isolated entry. The narrator uses the image of scattered points forming a picture. This is a scene of increasing knowledge, not a complete independent investigative report. Readers accompany Satyavrat as information formerly perceived in fragments acquires a more coherent and threatening significance. The alteration is interpretive: the underlying records already existed, but the relation now perceived among them changes the character's understanding. The chapter dramatises the assembly of evidence without reproducing the entire underlying ledger.

The Suggestion of Overseas Accounts and the Limits of Knowledge

The chain of transactions appears to reach across the sea, and certain names recur. Yet the chapter does not conclusively establish who directs the whole operation. Satyavrat wonders whether the network may extend towards the glass tower of earlier reports; the connection remains possible rather than proved. Readers can fruitfully relate this development to the shadowy overseas account encountered in Chapter [−32], but suspicion must not be promoted into confirmed fact. The narrative generates expectation by linking incomplete indications. Its dramatic strength depends upon the temporary boundary between the pattern the character can see and the criminal responsibility that remains to be demonstrated.

The "Decision" of the Title versus Immediate Action

The title may lead readers to expect an immediate public revelation or legal intervention. The prose instead ends with Satyavrat's ethical resolution, the safeguarding of his notebook, and the search for a suitable occasion to speak. No completed complaint procedure, arrest, or judicial outcome is narrated. An inward change has become definite, while the time for an effective outward act remains ahead. Conflating the two would destroy the chapter's tension: its interest lies in a person recognising both a duty and the danger that still complicates its performance. Decision is a moral development here, not shorthand for a successful operation already undertaken.

Seniority: A Change in the Limits of Access

Previously Satyavrat regarded himself as a minor bank employee. He now occupies a senior position, with somewhat greater access to transactions and a broader view of their interconnections. That change does not itself eliminate the risks associated with a powerful financial network. Instead, greater information reveals a more complicated set of relations. The character's institutional position alters his narrative function: earlier he could only suspect and make private notes; now his suspicion is more structured and public action seems closer. This progression marks a maturation of the plot rather than an announcement that he has already prevailed.

Burhbā's Role: Remembering Risk Rather Than Issuing an Order

Burhbā suggests that Satyavrat's moment to speak is drawing near while stressing caution, dependable details, and the need for honest allies. The dialogue continues the earlier discussion of silence. Burhbā does not lodge a complaint in Satyavrat's place, nor demand an immediate performance of heroism. The relationship preserves a distance between adviser and decision-maker. Satyavrat's own judgement remains active; the elder enlarges his awareness of danger and preparation. In this respect, the recurring authoritative figure does not entirely absorb the younger character's moral agency, and the still-unsettled outcome remains his responsibility.

Silence: From Absence to Preparation

Satyavrat had been silent while steadily writing details in his notebook. In the present chapter he says that keeping silent is no longer possible, even though the ending again involves awaiting the appropriate moment. The statements are not necessarily contradictory. They indicate different meanings of silence. Earlier, hesitation combined fear with prudence; now controlled restraint is linked to an intention to speak. The novel assigns

greater weight to this subtle change than to a spectacular speech. Silence is neither intrinsically heroic nor automatically cowardly. Its ethical significance depends upon the character's circumstances, intentions, and sense of the right time.

The Notebook's Double Role: Private Risk and Collective Future

Satyavrat's notebook preserves dates and transaction details. It belongs to the same material world of records as Gop Kumar's collection, Vibhā's documents, and Nand's new diary, but each object has a different narrative purpose. Satyavrat's is an instrument of private preservation and possible public disclosure; Gop Kumar's serves long-term communal memory; Nand's begins with a worker erased from an account. To speak of them simply as interchangeable registers would erase their separate histories of risk and use. Writing is a common action, but the conditions and consequences of the acts of writing remain distinct.

Bank Numbers and the People Missing from View

Accounts, amounts, and dates occupy much of Satyavrat's field of vision. Particular people who may have lost their savings do not receive developed voices in this episode. The narrative renders the organisation and possible scale of financial flows more visible than the suffering of identifiable victims. This choice is a significant distance in focalisation. Some names are familiar and others unfamiliar, but the mere occurrence of a name in the records does not establish that every named person is either a criminal or a victim. A faithful account must preserve the uncertain significance of those entries rather than assign roles that the narrator has not demonstrated.

"Do Not Fight Alone": The Social Character of Witnessing

Burhbā advises Satyavrat to seek honest officials or other trustworthy witnesses. Throughout the novel, names have been preserved through songs, registers, women's assemblies, and collective work. The struggle against a financial network is now also imagined as something requiring collaboration rather than a lone individual's power of observation. The social dimension of witnessing returns in another form. Yet no named collaborator actually joins him in this chapter, nor is a coordinated campaign launched and completed. The advice opens a strategic possibility. It should not be translated into a reported success before the appropriate events are narrated.

The Story of Fear: A Visible Risk and an Invisible Opponent

Satyavrat fears that the network may be powerful and ruthless, and Burhbā does not dismiss that possibility. The narrator suggests a wider danger but

does not bring the organisation's actual leaders onto the stage. The opposing force remains partly invisible. Against such an adversary, gathering scattered details takes on dramatic weight. The reader is aware of a threat without knowing the exact direction in which it may emerge. This incomplete information sustains the story's suspense. Satyavrat's anxiety is real as an experience, although each possible cause or future act of retaliation has not thereby been established as a completed event.

The Song's Resolve and the Prose's Waiting

The song declares that silence will break and the decision will not waver. The prose ends by showing the protected notebook and the continuing wait. The lyric carries the emphatic rhythm of collective courage; the story allows for the constraints of time, preparation, and an individual person's uncertainty. Their difference is productive. The song's high assurance gives ethical intensity to the situation, while the ordinary person's thoughtful caution becomes more credible in its presence. Neither narrative level should be forced to replace the other. The anticipated act of public speech remains distinct from the record of a resolve to undertake it.

The Unstable Timing of a Decision

Words meaning “now,” “near,” “gradually,” and “the right moment” recur throughout the chapter. They create a sense of imminent action without naming an exact date. Narrative time oscillates between approach and postponement. The possible explosion of events is still withheld. Together with the long silence of Chapter [–31], the new sense of proximity keeps the reader waiting for a consequential development. The delay is more than an empty repetition. It gives structural form to the risks involved in the emergence of a witness who must understand not merely what to say, but how and when to make it public.

Satyavrat's Personal Transformation

Satyavrat was introduced as a man who spoke little but observed much. He now learns to perceive patterns among the things he has recorded. His growth is therefore not simply an increase in the quantity of speech; private observation begins to become an understanding of wider social relations. He tells Burhbā that silence cannot continue. Fear and duty persist together in the exchange. This internal turn is the chapter's strongest achieved development, even as outward action is deferred. The character has changed before the community or the institution can fully see the consequences of that change.

Overall Assessment: The Night before Testimony

"Satyavrat's Decision" is, in effect, the eve of his possible public testimony. Years of notebook entries reveal a new pattern; the danger appears more clearly; Satyavrat recognises the limits of continued silence. Formal disclosure has not yet occurred. The chapter makes active a characteristic narrative method of the long novel: a consequential transformation begins within a person's consciousness before it appears upon the social stage. Maintaining the interval between inward decision and outward result permits a more responsible reading of whatever developments the subsequent narrative may bring.

Critical Section 83 | Original Chapter −18 — The Meeting of Ananya and Nand

The prehistory · A source-grounded narratological reading of the original novel

Rereading the "Meeting" of the Title

The title refers to the "meeting" of Ananya and Nand, although Chapter [−21] has already shown Ananya teaching Nand as a child. This cannot be their first acquaintance. The main prose makes clear that the teacher and the young engineer are now working together on a common project for the first time. The meeting is best understood as their new relationship as collaborators. A faithful reading cannot erase the classroom connection and invent a sudden encounter between strangers. The real development is a change in the social and practical level of a relationship that already has a history within the story.

Nand's Return and the Mature Result of Education

Having completed engineering studies, Nand returns to the village. The questioning education of his childhood and Aruni's construction tradition converge in this homecoming. He is no longer simply a pupil; he is a young engineer able to apply technical skills. Ananya, meanwhile, has been using the old songs, registers, and stories as material for teaching and investigation. Their capabilities have developed along different lines and now become associated through shared work. The course is narratively credible because the child's earlier questions do not produce an inexplicable instant achievement. Study and experience intervene before they become forms of community service.

Modernising the Coconut-Leaf School

The two begin working on a project associated with the school's modern branch, intending to preserve the village's heritage digitally. The school moves towards becoming not only an educational institution but also a centre of archival creation. Earlier, Pratima's computer and Devika's sound recordings represented developments in their respective media. Ananya and Nand now start a joint effort to bring old pages, folk songs, and names into relation with one another. Education, collection, and technology meet at one place. The process has begun; it is not a completed conversion of every document and every remembered voice into a permanent digital archive.

Questioning and Building: Two Different Characteristic Powers

Ananya's established role is that of a teacher who cultivates questions; Nand's is that of an engineer with the ability to construct and employ technology. The song pairs "question" and "construction" as complementary strengths. Their union is not one of identical personalities, but of different practices that can assist one another. Nand needs Ananya's knowledge of inherited stories, while Ananya's work can draw upon the tools Nand knows how to develop. The partnership becomes meaningful precisely because the kinds of labour remain distinguishable. Burhbā recognises their difference rather than treating either character as a substitute for the other.

The Continuation of Gop Kumar's Work

Burhbā explicitly says that Ananya and Nand are going to carry Gop Kumar's work forward. Gop Kumar had begun joining Yadavanand's old registers, the government documents recovered by Vibhā, and newer records. Their project constitutes another phase of organising such materials digitally. The narrative thus establishes a functional succession: an effort begun by one person becomes the joint responsibility of a later generation. It does not state that Gop Kumar's entire collection is already complete, or that Ananya and Nand can digitise the whole history on their first working day. The continuity lies in their shared undertaking, not in an already finished repository.

The Opening of Collaboration and the Deferral of Completion

The narrator announces the conjunction of their work, while Burhbā senses that a final chapter is drawing near. The word "near" remains significant. Beginning a project is a sign of an eventual comprehensive collection, not proof that a flawless archive is already available. The prose describes the start of gathering older papers, names, and songs. Its duration and later challenges are not fully displayed. The critical task is to preserve the gap between commencement and completion. By holding the destination ahead, the chapter gives the new partnership forward movement without prematurely ending the larger narrative's unresolved demands.

Technology and the Remediation of Memory

Folk songs and registers already exist in different forms: human voice, leaf, paper, and digital text. Ananya and Nand seek to coordinate such media. Placing an old name on a screen, however, does not automatically preserve the living vocal quality of a song; Devika's earlier work on sound recordings has already raised this issue. The present chapter does not provide a detailed technical account of how the materials will be digitised,

catalogued, and maintained. A claim that every name is now "immortal" represents an aspiration of the characters, not a physically demonstrated result. The value of the project lies in the attempt at mediation and continuity.

The Song's Metaphor of Convergence

The folk song repeatedly imagines two paths meeting at one place. The image gives the characters' earlier lives a common destination. In the prose, their cooperation is not a miraculous accidental encounter but a deliberate decision to work together, rooted in the school's modernisation. The song celebrates the convergence emotionally; the prose identifies its practical setting. Read together, the two levels show a characteristic method of the novel: recognisable institutional labour is granted the symbolic significance of generations of communal memory flowing together. The metaphor gives importance to the act without replacing the act itself.

One Purpose, Distinct Responsibilities

Ananya brings familiarity with older songs and registers; Nand brings expertise in digital transformation. Both want to protect memory, but a shared aim does not make their individual work indistinguishable. The division of labour is the source of the partnership's meaning. Flattening the two into a single idealised voice would weaken the chapter's active plurality. In particular, reducing Ananya to a companion who merely inspires Nand would misrepresent her intellectual contribution and prior educational work. The project draws equally upon her knowledge and his technical skills, though those contributions take different forms.

Burhbā's Metaphor of Two Shoulders

Burhbā calls the task of witnessing a burden that can be made lighter by two shoulders. The image directly recalls the responsibility placed upon Nand in the chapter of his birth. Then, the child was a possible bearer of a future weight; now, as an adult working with someone else, he can share it. The transition changes the anticipated solitary hero into a participant in collective labour. Yet Burhbā also suggests that the final crisis may be difficult. Such a statement remains a forewarning. The particular crisis has not already occurred within this chapter simply because the partnership has begun.

A Hint of a Personal Relationship beyond Cooperation

The closing sentence anticipates that their shared journey will eventually bind their lives together. This is a narratorial forecast. The chapter contains no explicit marriage, betrothal, proposal of love, or final

definition of their personal relationship. What the reader actually sees is agreement in values and the beginning of sustained common work. An emotional possibility can reasonably be perceived, but it cannot be reported as a concluded personal event. Leaving the matter open respects the narrative's gradual disclosure and the characters' still-developing freedom to make choices.

A New Period in the Village's Memory

The chapter's time is not fixed motionlessly between an old register and a new digital device. It moves toward a future. Nand's return as an engineer, Ananya's teaching tradition, and Gop Kumar's collecting work meet in a present action directed towards an extended goal. Nevertheless, the statement that the "final chapter" is approaching retains a sense of unfinished business. The characters' convergence is not the end of the story. It provides an outline for what must still take place, allowing historical inheritance and future responsibility to occupy the same narrative moment.

The Limits of Fully Visualising the Collective Work

The prose refers to the collection of pages, songs, and names but does not specify how many pages were assembled, whose song was first transcribed, or which particular technical difficulties were encountered. These absences should not be filled with invented quantities, software systems, or successes. The main aim is to bring the narrative courses of two important characters together rather than offer a detailed account of archival operations. Accordingly, the reader experiences the emotional and intergenerational significance of the work more fully than its practical technical procedures. That imbalance belongs in an exact assessment of the chapter.

Ananya's Earlier Classroom and Their Present Equality

In childhood, Nand learnt Ananya's method of asking questions. In the present chapter, they collaborate on a common project. The old inequality between teacher and pupil has, through time and development, become a relationship of colleagues. This indicates the effectiveness of Nand's education without canceling the significance of Ananya's earlier contribution. She once gave him a language for questioning the world of stories; he now adds technological means of construction to that language. Their changing relation displays the maturation of both characters rather than the domination of either one.

The Convergence of Three Earlier Foreshadowings

Burhbā's exceptional hope at Nand's birth, Gop Kumar's expectation of a final chapter, and the classroom prediction that Nand's questioning would

matter in a future conflict all meet in the present episode. The story begins to demonstrate how separately established anticipations may become related through practical cooperation. It does not yet reveal their ultimate outcome. The arrangement is structurally valuable because connections formerly stated as hopes or fears start to acquire a visible social form. The reader becomes better prepared for the future without being told that the future has already been resolved.

Overall Assessment: Preparing to Bear Witness Together

The central event of "The Meeting of Ananya and Nand" is their collaboration on a shared heritage project at the school. The title does not erase their childhood acquaintance; it repositions the relationship at the level of a new duty. Two sets of skills, two trajectories of growth, and the continuation of an earlier archive combine to create a collective structure for future witnessing. The song speaks in the language of convergence, while the prose shows an unfinished practical undertaking. The chapter is not a declaration of final accomplishment. It is a preparation—social, emotional, and technological—for the decisive events still ahead.

Critical Section 84 | Original Chapter −17 — The Web of the Glass Tower

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Glass Tower: Visible Brilliance and Invisible Operations

The "glass tower" rises visibly towards the sky, yet the commercial organisation within it is never directly staged before the reader. The narrator sets its shining architecture against the concealed network that supposedly operates behind it. The distance between exterior surface and interior intention supplies the episode's central narrative energy. Far from the familiar peepal, pond and village meeting-place of Garh Narikel, the tower becomes a transoceanic emblem. The centre of narration nonetheless remains the village. Rather than taking the reader inside the suspected building, the novel approaches it by means of news reports, an atmosphere of rumour and the inferences of its characters. Its physical visibility does not make the workings attributed to it transparent.

News Media: What Is Reported and What Is Seen

The prose begins with repeatedly circulating news of digital fraud reportedly operating from Hong Kong. News accounts associate the name Lau Kin-hung with the operation. The narrator describes the purported extent of the network, but presents no independent scenes of particular victims giving testimony, no judicial record, and no direct enactment of its criminal administration in this chapter. Knowledge mediated by news must therefore be distinguished from knowledge obtained through a narrated eyewitness scene. Ananya and Nand hear discussion of the network; they have not themselves entered the tower to examine it. Repeated reports intensify apprehension without eliminating distance from their sources. A critic must neither suppress the reports nor convert their mediated claims into fully demonstrated scenes.

Three Economic Traps Brought Within One Narrative Frame

Fraudulent recruitment, investment deception and human trafficking are presented as different extremities of an expansive network. This threefold arrangement brings strands previously considered in separate chapters—online employment fraud, deceptive representations and the market in bodies—into a prospective common plot. The song's expression "three crocodiles" makes this organisation memorable. It does not follow, however, that the present chapter dramatises three detailed, newly completed incidents. The main prose chiefly offers an overview of the alleged machinery and shows its apprehensive reception in the village. The

distinct earlier events may now be read as parallel narrative lines, but the gaps in their factual or causal connections must not be filled with imagined transactions, victims or meetings.

The Three "Crocodiles": The Changing Work of a Metaphor

The crocodile once belonged to dangers posed by the river and pond; subsequently it named screen-based fraud and forms of invisible social predation. Here it threatens bodies, money and names alike. By extending the original image through successive historical settings, the novel creates continuity without preserving an identical meaning. The aquatic creature of the earlier stories cannot be treated as the biological agent of the present financial crimes. The metaphor's strength lies in the way a formerly natural fear gives an ethical name to organised, transnational human violence. A recurrent symbol is therefore not a static equivalence. Its historical metamorphosis is part of the long narrative's form, and its different referents require separate analysis.

The Network's Apparent Totality and the Characters' Incomplete Knowledge

The narrator observes that nobody could see the entire system at one location, yet proceeds to bring together its recruitment, investment and coercive-labour strands in an overarching description. This produces a significant disparity between the narrator's synoptic reach and the characters' limited perspectives. Ananya and Nand acquire apprehensions gradually; readers receive a somewhat larger outline of the danger. Even that outline is incomplete. The operators' full identities, every connection among them and the precise next calamity remain unrevealed. The narrative manages knowledge and ignorance simultaneously. Its panoramic presentation generates suspense precisely because it does not furnish a complete evidentiary dossier or remove the questions that the characters still have to confront.

The Return of Abhinav's Earlier News Report

In Chapter [−32], Abhinav read of a glass tower and an uncertain name in a newspaper. The present chapter recalls that report, making an earlier hint into a bridge across the narrative. What was then an indistinct overseas shadow now acquires the contours of a larger reported criminal arrangement. This is not simply repetition of an identical occurrence; it increases the density of a previously planted sign. Continued public discussion brings the distant threat into Ananya and Nand's contemporary concerns. Yet recurrence does not retrospectively establish every conjecture made during Abhinav's first reading. The novel assembles fragments of

foreshadowing without delivering the final disclosure. The critic must recognise both continuity and the limits of confirmation.

Ujjwal and Batuknath: Different Lives Brought Together in Memory

Burhbā recalls Ujjwal's ominous future and Batuknath's decline as possibly relevant to the wider network. Their narrative positions differ. Ujjwal's danger has so far been conveyed principally through a vision at his birth; Batuknath's deviation from ethical legal practice has been narrated as conduct already occurring. They are not two equally established offenders. When Burhbā senses that the network may have reached the village already, he brings the two strands into a common field of apprehension, not a table of verified financial connections. This narrative preparation heightens expectation while withholding Ujjwal's actual fate, any conclusive international complicity by Batuknath, and the precise identity of an injured individual.

Ananya and Nand: From a Joint Project to a Shared Apprehension

In the preceding section, Ananya and Nand worked together on a digital archive for the village. Their collaboration now provides the social setting in which they confront news of a new threat. The irony is pointed: digital tools that might preserve communal memory exist within the same larger technological world as new instruments of deception. Ananya translates anxiety into a question addressed to Burhbā; Nand participates in their common concern. Neither completes a digital investigation of the network or brings about an arrest here. Their work extends from preservation towards critical alertness. The shift represents an enlargement of responsibility, not a completed victory over the invisible organisation.

"It May Already Have Arrived": Psychological Rather Than Physical Entry

Ananya asks whether the network could reach Garh Narikel; Burhbā replies that perhaps it has arrived already. Arrival need not mean the physical entrance of a named agent. The influence of distant structures can also be imagined within a person's aspirations, failures, dreams and fears. Such internalisation of the external world is the episode's distinctive literary procedure. The village retains geographical boundaries, but communications, credit and circulating news expose it to remote forces. Burhbā's answer is an apprehension expressed through experience and metaphor, not a map tracing the crossing of an identified criminal. The uncertainty of what "arrival" signifies creates much of the statement's force.

A Future "Name": Concentrating a Multiplicity of Threats

Burhbā fears that the vast network will one day touch "one name" in the village. The novel's longstanding concern with remembering names thereby becomes the focus of prospective action. Setting one individual against a transnational organisation is a technique of powerful concentration. Yet the person has not been identified, and Burhbā expressly admits that he does not know which name will be involved. Readers may search for connections among the characters already introduced, but the narrative has not authorised a determinate answer. The unnamed future victim or participant turns the size of the danger into a personal expectation without prematurely claiming that the decisive injury has occurred.

Burhbā's Fear and His Admission of Limits

The long-lived witness possesses a memory of many successive "crocodiles" but cannot specify whom the coming disaster will strike. Experience and uncertainty coexist in his speech. He is not constructed here as an omniscient prophet who has already witnessed every detail of the future. His reflections provide figurative foreshadowing, not a retrospective account of an event already completed. A rigorous reading therefore asks at what level each statement is offered: felt danger, metaphorical comparison or independently established outcome. Blurring these levels would dispose of the novel's suspense before the narrated time allows it. Burhbā's fear is meaningful even when its object remains unknown.

The Warning Campaign as the Actual Concluding Action

Ananya's renewed warning to the village's young people is the chapter's definite final act. This public engagement develops the established history of women's night assemblies, inquiry-based education and local digital-safety groups. It is not the dismantling of the criminal network. The teacher moves beyond merely expressing fear by deciding upon concrete communication with her community. After outlining a danger of extraordinary scale, the narrative closes with a limited local measure. The disproportion is instructive: collective preparation matters, but the structure being feared appears much larger than the community's immediate power. A warning campaign is a response to potential danger, not proof that danger has been eliminated.

The Song's Certainty and the Prose's Conditional Language

The "Three Crocodiles" song presents fraud, investment traps and trafficking within a single confident formula and urges listeners to proceed only after scrutiny. The prose, by contrast, relies on reports, conversations, Burhbā's impressions and conditional expressions such as "perhaps." The

song formulates communal knowledge as an imperative; the characters' present information remains restricted. Its instruction may sound like a promise of eventual victory, but the prose contains neither an arrest nor the destruction of the system. Their difference can be read as a method of preparing the next crisis rather than merely as a flaw. The collective voice supplies resolution in language before the plot can supply it through events.

Panoramic Narration and the Invisibility of Victims

The network is said to reach dozens of countries, but this chapter does not introduce a newly named victim, a developed account of bodily suffering or a direct individual testimony. Economic crime is gathered into a narrative overview. Such compression makes the global danger imaginable while pushing the distinctive voices of those harmed into the background. The promise of a future encounter with "one name" indicates that the present chapter is drawing a broad frame rather than completing an individual life story. Criticism must recognise the value of that frame and the cost of its restricted representation. Scale is not the same as a plurality of fully dramatised experiences.

The Narrative Use of "Near" in a Long Work

Near the end, the coming decisive day is described as "not far away." No date is assigned, and no exact chain of imminent actions is given. For generations, the book has repeatedly anticipated a "final chapter." Here the language of approaching time makes the pressure feel more intense, even while the promised incident remains absent. "Near" thus has a structural rather than calendrical force. Repeated declarations can deepen suspense, but they can also make delay perceptible. The development that actually occurs in this chapter is the sharpening of communal vigilance, not the arrival of the outcome itself. The critic should read proximity as an effect of narrative organisation.

Overall Assessment: The Local Edge of a Global Shadow

The significance of "The Web of the Glass Tower" lies less in a dramatic unveiling of criminals than in the geographical expansion of danger. The song furnishes its three-crocodile metaphor; reports lend it a purported name and extent; Ananya acts by warning young people; Burhbā fears harm to an as-yet-unidentified person. These levels bring inherited communal remembrance into contact with distant digital finance. The main prose has not yet exposed the full machinery or demonstrated the decisive injury in the village. Its incompleteness is part of its preparatory function. The ancient undertaking to protect names now faces a threat

whose distance, mediation and financial opacity frustrate the older forms of witnessing.

Critical Section 85 | Original Chapter −16 — Batuknath's Final Turning

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Two Possible Meanings of the "Final Turning"

The title invites the expectation of a decisive change in Batuknath's life. The song maintains that he eventually returned to his own name, whereas the introductory prose and the narrated actions show him committing his legal skills more completely to the interests of unjust power. This produces a serious tension among title, song and prose. If "final turning" means moral reform, the narrated conduct does not fulfil that expectation. If it means the deepest stage of his decline, the prose becomes intelligible but the song's claim of return remains unanswered. Criticism must state the discrepancy rather than reconcile the levels by silently inventing repentance. The text's different voices are not interchangeable records of one completed transformation.

Comparing the Earlier Batuknath with His Present Self

Chapter [−33] introduced a gifted student who first represented the poor and then gradually became a compromised lawyer. When a widow came before him in a dispute over her field, an image of his earlier village life briefly entered his consciousness. The present chapter offers almost no comparable scene of inner resistance. Instead, it summarises a systematic use of his professional skills in the service of stronger clients. His descent therefore appears as the extended consequence of a disposition established earlier, not an isolated sudden betrayal. Reading the two chapters together reveals a career arc, although individual steps in that arc remain thinly dramatised. The possibility of improvement once glimpsed must be measured against his present conduct, not mistaken for actual recovery.

"News Arrived": The Indirect Route of Narration

The first narrative development is the arrival in the village of news about Batuknath's professional transformation. Readers are not taken through a complete courtroom case. Repeatedly obtaining adjournments, exhausting witnesses and entangling the proceedings become habitual actions summarised by the narrator. This method makes his reputation and misconduct appear structural, but leaves the particular court, hearing, judgment and individual victim's final position unspecified. The narrative selects a concise professional portrait instead of dramatising a few lengthy cases. Its authority comes from the narrator's account of a pattern; it does not supply the documents or personal testimony required to reconstruct

every alleged act. The mediation of the news must remain visible in the criticism.

Adjournment after Adjournment: The Distortion of Judicial Time

Repeated adjournments are the chapter's most important temporal device. Legal time ought to allow a dispute to proceed towards resolution; Batuknath turns it into an instrument of attrition. Delay itself becomes an outcome when the injured party grows tired of waiting and falls silent. Violence here need not take the form of physical assault in the courtroom. It acts through the administration of duration. Throughout the long novel, protecting a name has meant resisting time's erasures. In this chapter, a lawyer deliberately makes time work against those seeking recognition. These opposite ethical uses of time establish a pointed contrast between communal witnessing and the manipulation of the legal process.

The Light of Prestige and the Darkness of Conduct

Batuknath's wealth and public success increase, while the prose assigns an increasingly negative moral value to the means of that success. The ordinary vocabulary of winning and losing is reversed: a lawyer's victory can conceal the defeat of the poor. This irony is forceful, although no full sequence of court decisions or injuries is reproduced. Readers confront two standards of valuation at once—professional reputation and communal ethical judgment. The song continues to hold out an image of return, but the account of his growing prestige intensifies rather than resolves the darkness attached to his practice. The chapter therefore resists any arithmetic in which success in one institution automatically constitutes moral achievement.

The Village as Witness and the City's Reputation: Two Ways of Naming

Batuknath's name circulates in the city as that of a formidable defence lawyer, while the village also remembers the gifted and honest child he once was. These are not competing accounts of the same moment. They belong to different periods of his life. Burhbā does not use his former goodness to excuse the acts of the present. The village's narrative task is to preserve the contradictory phases of one life in their proper sequence. Remembering a name no longer means honouring an innocent victim alone; it also means keeping the uncomfortable record of someone whose choices have become unjust. This is a demanding enlargement of the novel's ethics of memory.

Nand's Grief and Burhbā's Reply

Nand grieves that Batuknath has turned decisively towards darkness. Burhbā does not advise him to erase the lawyer's name. He recognises that certain names remain sources of pain even when preserved. Their exchange clarifies the limits of a witness's vocation. Burhbā cannot change every person's decisions; he can try to keep the sequence of that person's life truthful. The elder thereby emerges less as an all-powerful moral governor than as a difficult historian. Nand's grief remains meaningful, but grief alone cannot determine which facts should survive in the record. The scene separates the emotional response to wrongdoing from the discipline of describing it without falsification.

"Neither Hatred nor Forgiveness": A Deliberate Restraint of Judgment

Nand records Batuknath's history "without hatred and without forgiveness." The expression does not neutralise the wrong: the prose explicitly identifies the lawyer's present conduct as unjust. Instead, the witness avoids two different falsifications. Condemnation must not become an excuse to destroy the facts of a life, and affection for a former companion must not become an excuse to hide his misconduct. Between these extremes lies the difficult work of keeping successive stages of a character's history in their proper relation. Such restraint exemplifies a literary rather than a purely punitive conception of justice. It refuses both the artificial saint and the artificially featureless villain.

The Causes of Decline: System, Temptation and Choice

The final reflection brings together the institutional system, the attraction of reward and the individual's decisions. It would be mistaken to turn these three factors into an exclusively deterministic account that absolves Batuknath of responsibility. Equally, the narrative rejects the notion that he was born irredeemably corrupt. His ethical development is placed within an evolving history of environment and practice. Burhbā presents remembrance as the preservation of this complexity. Readers are asked to consider conditions that enable injustice without forgetting the decisions through which a person may reproduce it. The chapter's psychological account is not exhaustive, but it deliberately resists both innate-villain explanations and complete institutional exoneration.

The Earlier Widow's Unanswered Case

In Chapter [−33], a poor widow confronted Batuknath over a case concerning her field. The present chapter does not disclose the judgment in that particular case or describe the widow's subsequent life. This

omission matters because the lawyer's declining practice receives an extensive general account while an individual whose suffering once interrupted his conscience receives no corresponding resolution. Criticism cannot supply the missing verdict, whether victory or defeat. The silence stands alongside the broader moral pronouncements as an unresolved individual question. Its presence is particularly telling in a novel committed to preserving distinct lives rather than reducing them to the unnamed representatives of an injured class.

The Song's Return and the Prose's Descent: A Structural Inconsistency

The song repeatedly says that Batuknath returned towards his name. Yet the main prose records no act of repentance, apology to a victim, withdrawal from an improper brief or practical restoration of justice. It depicts the opposite: deeper professional service to wrongdoing. To dismiss this conflict merely as optimistic singing would minimise a real divergence between the narrative levels. Perhaps the song anticipates a later possibility, but the prose does not make a clear promise of such a future either. The unperformed redemption must therefore remain an unresolved textual tension, not a fact inferred from lyric assurance. The literary reading gains precision by leaving the discrepancy open.

Remembering a Guilty Name: The Ethical Challenge of Testimony

Earlier naming rituals largely commemorated victims, the dead and those deprived of recognition. Here a person increasingly responsible for injustice must also have his life recorded. The ethics of remembrance is no longer identical with sympathetic homage. Erasing the wrongdoer's name could render the injustice itself harder to trace, while converting his name into an honoured monument could imply exoneration. The prose seeks a route between these errors through careful registration of conduct and its changes over time. The witness must retain the name without purifying the history. This constitutes one of the more difficult extensions of the long narrative's concern with memory.

Nand's Diary: The Practice of Inherited Witnessing

Nand enters Batuknath's whole course of life into his record. His diary, first associated with “The Account of the Splash” and the erased name of a worker, now includes the moral decline of a lawyer. The young engineer thus becomes a writer-witness of the community's ethically troubling stories. His action exceeds the passive repetition of Burhbā's instructions because he chooses a difficult subject. Nevertheless, the chapter reports documentation, not a specific legal petition against Batuknath or an organised courtroom campaign. Nand's intervention occurs at the level of

narrative representation. His diary begins to hold a wider range of human conduct, without acquiring the power to reverse that conduct by writing it down.

The Incomplete Finality of the Word "Final"

Although "final" suggests closure, the prose does not declare every possible future course of Batuknath's life ended. Burhbā's admission that changing another's decision is not his work marks a limit to his own intervention, not the character's death. Nand records a life as it has unfolded so far; the lawyer remains alive and another stage is still possible. The title may therefore name an extreme point in the present moral descent rather than a conclusive end to the biography. The song's image of possible return and the prose's definite deterioration continue to pull in different directions. Their unresolved relation remains a question for subsequent chapters.

Sparse Scenes and Extended Commentary

Batuknath's present courtroom work is narrated more often in summary than through detailed scenes, while Burhbā's ethical explanation receives greater space. This distribution clarifies the guiding judgment but limits access to the actions in any particular case. Judicial delay is the object of criticism without being extensively staged as an individual proceeding. The literary advantage is conceptual emphasis; the representational cost is the restricted voice of each person harmed. A strictly narratological assessment must hold these results together. It should neither accept the chapter solely as an admirable moral lesson nor invent cases to make its narrative denser than it actually is.

Corrupt Prestige in the Long History of Justice

Batuknath's career recalls Sukhdev, Bhola and earlier struggles with judicial institutions. Previously, disadvantaged claimants encountered delay as an obstacle; now an educated professional uses that very delay as a weapon. The repetition reverses the moral placement of legal expertise. Education and social advancement do not automatically extinguish injustice. A person equipped with the language of rights may help perpetuate the mechanisms through which those rights are frustrated. This brings an additional responsibility to the chronicler: negative consequences of progress must be preserved alongside its achievements. Batuknath's prestigious name belongs to the history of wrongs precisely because prestige can conceal them.

Overall Assessment: A Song of Hope, a Record of Decline

"The Final Turning of Batuknath" is among the long narrative's more complex accounts of moral inheritance. Its prose gives an overview of

professional degeneration, harm to the poor and Nand's restrained documentation as a witness. The folk song suggests return, but the narrated sequence fails to enact that return. This critical inconsistency must not be disregarded. Burhbā's response establishes the present responsibility clearly: preserve the name with its wrongdoing intact; do not invent redemption. The chapter is therefore not only a criticism of a lawyer. It is also a declaration of the limits and duties of narrative witnessing when its subject is someone the community once admired.

Critical Section 86 | Original Chapter −15 — Chandrapal's Account

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From a Distant Birth to the Centre of a Financial Event

Chandrapal Batra entered the narrative in Chapter [−29] as a child born in Meerut to a family with remote village connections. At that point the song foreshadowed signatures and deception, but the main prose narrated only the birth, the attenuated relationship to Garh Narikel and his entry in Gop Kumar's register. His indebted present is now brought into view. This is a delayed partial fulfilment of an earlier narrative hint. It does not disclose an entire life history, all the episodes of betting or the final legal consequence. The critic must measure what the present action actually confirms rather than treating every element of the earlier song as already verified.

Betting Debt as an Initial Pressure upon Decision

The prose relates Chandrapal's serious betting debts to his vulnerability. To a person worn down and despondent under such obligations, an offer of paid "commission" work can resemble immediate relief. The portrayal is not reducible to an uncomplicated vice of greed; it combines pressure, incomplete understanding and the hope of escape. Chandrapal does actually receive and forward money, allowing funds taken from others to pass through his account. But the financial pressure does not automatically absolve him of responsibility for that conduct. The chapter complicates the conventional separation of innocent victim and knowing perpetrator: someone trapped by his own losses may also participate in a system that harms others. His precise private history remains incompletely disclosed.

"Commission Work": A Deceptive Ordinary Name

Chandrapal is told that sums will enter his account, that he should forward them, and that he may keep a portion. Calling this "commission work" gives a dangerous arrangement the appearance of ordinary employment. The narrative exposes the deception concealed in that commonplace phrase. Language is part of the action: a harmful structure acquires credibility when it adopts the vocabulary of legitimate earnings. The weakness in Chandrapal's decision begins, in part, with how the activity is named. Critical analysis should rely on this described practice and its reported language, not on invented contractual clauses or imaginary banking procedures. What the prose establishes is the

circulation of money for a commission; it does not present a complete written agreement.

The Account: From Personal Identifier to Transit Point

A bank account normally records a person's financial dealings, but here it becomes a node through which sums enter and are forwarded elsewhere. Chandrapal's name is attached to movement whose wider purpose he does not fully understand. The moral significance of naming changes: a personal identifier becomes an instrument for transferring other people's stolen money. The network's operation depends upon distance and unfamiliarity between its many accounts and holders. A numerical record alone does not disclose the whole crime. The narrator situates the transactions within a broad plot whose participants have unequal access to its meaning. The separation between name, account and human purpose is the chapter's central tension.

The "Mule Account": Narrative Definition and Actual Conduct

The introductory account calls Chandrapal a conduit through a "mule account." The prose supplies the basic behaviour behind the term: accepting funds, passing them onwards and retaining a share. This allows readers to understand his role without mistaking the book for a technical manual. The exact number of transfers, the branch concerned and any arrest under a specified legal provision are not given. The narrative's definitional clarity thus coexists with limited incident-specific detail. Its interest lies in the character's partial understanding and ethical entanglement, not in reconstructing every operation in the suspected financial network. Criticism should preserve both the identifiable activity and the extent of what is not stated.

Between Ignorance and Responsibility: The Moral Grey Area

Chandrapal does "not fully understand" how his account is being used. This blocks any claim that he knowingly approved every concealed purpose of the larger operation. Yet he knowingly forwards funds for payment. He is not an entirely passive spectator either. The narrative combines deficient knowledge with actual deeds. The song treats ignorance as one of the knots in the trap, suggesting that unexamined conduct can become a link in harm to strangers. The resulting moral ambiguity is essential. Chandrapal should be represented neither as the unquestionable mastermind of the whole scheme nor as automatically innocent because he lacked complete information. The narrative offers a middle condition that remains open to further examination.

Satyavrat's Observation: Linking a Private Life to a Structural Pattern

Satyavrat notices the movements through Chandrapal's account by consulting his accumulated banking notes. His perspective places one person's apparent commission work within a much larger pattern. Readers therefore encounter unequal kinds of knowledge. Chandrapal knows the immediate transactions and his own promised reward; Satyavrat sees relationships among several accounts. The discrepancy creates narrative tension. But the banker has not filed a completed public indictment or secured judgment in this chapter. He is still assembling information that might matter to future testimony. Recognising the network's possible shape and establishing its legal disposition are different stages of action. The criticism must not transform an investigator's growing insight into a finished prosecution.

Four Names Named Together: One Network, Four Distinct Positions

Burhbā juxtaposes Ujjwal, Batuknath, Chandrapal and the shadow of the distant tower. Their textual positions are not equivalent. Ujjwal's danger is still largely a matter of foreshadowing; Batuknath's decline has been narrated through professional conduct; Chandrapal's account is shown as a channel for current transfers; and the overseas shadow remains mediated through reports and inference. Naming them together prepares a possible future convergence. It does not establish equal guilt, shared knowledge or participation in a single completed meeting. To level their different statuses into one accusation would violate the very responsibility towards individual names that the narrative repeatedly advocates. Their association is a prospective plot structure, not a verdict.

Characters Who Do Not Know One Another: Dramatic Irony

Burhbā says that Ujjwal, Batuknath, Chandrapal and the faraway power are unknown to one another. The reader nonetheless possesses hints of relationships supplied by the longer narrative and the elder's synoptic apprehension. This produces dramatic irony: each person occupies a limited present, while the reading experience begins to assemble a map wider than anyone's immediate awareness. Even for the reader, the meeting points remain unsettled. Who will encounter whom, when, and in what capacity has not been narrated. The work draws distant names towards a possible common centre without granting them a premature encounter. Its suspense depends upon the difference between perceived connection and established action.

Private Account, Public Register and the Notebook of Suspicion

The old shadow register protected the names of those denied recognition; Chandrapal's account circulates funds obtained by deception; Satyavrat's

notebook records suspicious financial movements. All three involve written or numerical information, but their social functions differ. The novel does not treat writing as inherently sacred or inherently oppressive. Records can conceal and propagate injustice as well as preserve its traces for examination. Their ethical force depends upon use, accessibility and the real people whose names they bear. The juxtaposition enlarges the central theme from the simple preservation of names to the question of what different institutions do through names and numbers. Materially similar documents can occupy opposed places in the plot.

Signatures in the Song, Transfers in the Prose

The opening saying and song repeatedly warn against signing without understanding. The main prose, however, describes use of the account, onward transfers and commission. It does not separately stage a particular document being signed or reproduce a fraudulent contract. The difference is small but important. The lyric supplies a memorable moral formula about careless consent; the prose shows an economic process. Supplying a definite forged agreement or a specific signature scene would turn the song's warning into an event for which the narrative provides no evidence. In this chapter especially, the credibility of criticism depends upon preserving the distinct functions of the lyric and the enacted financial movements.

"In Every Transaction": The Narrator's Sweeping Claim

The prose states that money stolen from some poor person flowed through each such transaction. The assertion gives the scheme a serious moral scale, yet individual victims, precise sums and personal testimonies are not supplied for each transfer. The narrator offers a general account rather than an inspectable set of separate records. Criticism should examine the difference between the strength of the statement and the specificity of its presentation. The text gives no complete ledger through which every movement can be verified independently. What it creates is the impression of an invisible criminal mechanism built from harm to numerous unnamed people. That impression must be acknowledged without fabricating their separate stories.

The Temporality of the Expected "Final Chapter"

Burhbā again anticipates a moment when the dispersed names will come together. Satyavrat likewise awaits the possible public use of his long-kept notebook. After repeated promises that the decisive chapter is near, the bank-account episode adds a concrete channel through which the lines may intersect. Yet the present action remains limited: one person is embroiled in debt and financial transfers, while another preserves records.

The ultimate confrontation has not taken place. The narrative creates a deferred point of convergence and sustains interest through the interval before it. Expectation is an active feature of its temporal design, not a substitute for the missing culminating scene.

The Transformed Economic Form of Overseas Migration

In earlier stories of migration, bodies travelled overseas for labour and remittances returned home. Chandrapal's body remains in his city while his account allows money to cross great distances within a fraudulent system. Financial mobility thus extends the older concern with displacement into a world not dependent upon physical departure. Born in Meerut and connected only distantly with the village, Chandrapal becomes involved in a network whose transfers may draw him towards Garh Narikel's narrative centre. The geography of names now extends through accounts as well as roads, ships and labour contracts. The comparison reveals historical change without making the different experiences of migration and financial fraud identical.

The Ethical Formula and the Character's Independence

The song counsels the listener to understand before signing. Chandrapal's conduct nevertheless arises within debt, despair and a desire for immediate relief. The maxim alone cannot explain the character. He possesses an earlier birth episode, an attenuated relationship to the village and a distinct financial predicament. These details make him more than an interchangeable example appended to an educational warning. At the same time, the prose offers little developed first-person self-examination, remorse or sustained psychological monologue. His agency must be read within both the circumstances named and the interior life left unexplored. Moral instruction and individual causation are related, but neither can simply replace the other.

Overall Assessment: The Narrative Network Within an Account

"Chandrapal's Account" supplies a financial connection between several previously scattered anticipations. Chandrapal's debt and the lure of commission, Satyavrat's developing understanding, Burhbā's juxtaposition of four names and the postponed prospect of testimony are brought into one field. The chapter shows a morally ambiguous human intermediary in economic crime but does not establish each person's final legal status or the network's complete disposition. The contrast between the song's emphasis on signatures and the prose's actual account movements deepens the significance of misunderstanding. How long a name can remain caught in a system it only partly comprehends becomes a question for the future narrative rather than an answered verdict here.

Critical Section 87 | Original Chapter −14 — Construction of the Bridge

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Bridge Comes to the Centre of the Action

Nand is appointed an assistant to the chief engineer at a new bridge under construction across the Kamala-Balan near the village. The bridge now becomes a definite workplace, not merely a metaphor for hope. In Chapter [−20], Nand heard of a worker whose name had disappeared from a contractor's register; here the geographical situation and his position on the project are more clearly established. The narrative brings his sense of social witnessing back to construction and places infrastructure alongside the human histories of those who make it possible. The shift is important because a professional setting becomes the place where the old theme of the missing name confronts the realities of development.

"Assistant to the Chief Engineer": The Precise Limit of His Position

Nand is the chief engineer's assistant, not the chief engineer himself. The distinction matters for interpreting his capacity to act. He disputes safety practices with a contractor and records workers' names, but the novel does not place complete control over the project's administration in his hands. His initiative operates within an institutional hierarchy. This limitation gives his efforts their dramatic significance: responsibility expands even when formal power remains restricted. To describe him as the owner or supreme manager of the project would remove the structural tension present in the text. His emerging heroism consists in assuming obligations from a subordinate position rather than exercising unlimited authority.

The Promise of Shorter Journeys: A New Village–City Relationship

Completion of the bridge is expected to reduce a journey of hours to minutes. This compression of time promises more than transport convenience; it suggests a changed relationship between the long-established village and the wider world. Radio, telephones and computers earlier reduced the distance between messages, while the bridge would alter the movement of bodies. The different technologies must not be collapsed into one identical narrative function. The bridge has not yet opened to traffic in this chapter. The anticipated reduction in travel time is therefore a projection, not a measurement of journeys already undertaken. The story presents a social possibility produced by infrastructure still being made.

Workers' Bodies and Names: The Unseen Side of Construction

Nand observes inadequate safety, work at height without helmets and a contractor's habit of treating workers as numbers. The vulnerable bodies of labourers are set against the large scale of the bridge they are building. Development thus acquires a human cost within the same scene that promises a new connection. The question-asking disposition developed in Ananya's classroom becomes practical social scrutiny. Nand looks beyond the structural design towards the lives that support it. The narration integrates his engineering role with ethical awareness, although the workers themselves still receive relatively little extended independent dialogue. Their exposure is visible, while their full subjectivities remain only partially represented.

The Earlier Missing Worker's Story Returns

Nand remembers the account of a labourer who vanished from a previous construction site and whose name was erased from the contractor's records. The recollection binds this chapter to [−20]. It does not establish that a second worker has disappeared on the present bridge project. Remembered danger is a background for precaution, not a fresh incident to be added to the count of events. Readers understand Nand's vigilance because they know the earlier story, even though this site has not yet been shown to witness a definite death, disappearance or drowning. Distinguishing recollection from new action is essential to the novel's accumulation of memory across separate episodes.

Unfamiliar Visitors and Incomplete Identification

Contractors, intermediaries and unfamiliar people from distant cities move through the construction site, and their individual purposes are not fully identified. Their arrival opens a possible entry point for the larger criminal network, but the text does not declare all strangers accomplices. Unfamiliarity and culpability remain separate categories. Their uncertain status gives the bridge a double potential: a route joining the village to opportunity can also expose it to exploitation. The narrator maintains the limits of Nand's knowledge and lets readers anticipate developments without conferring a premature criminal identity upon every newcomer. The construction ground becomes a scene of contact and apprehension rather than a completed conspiracy.

Kamala-Balan: From Natural Background to Active Risk

The Kamala-Balan challenged human life in earlier flood episodes; now an engineered crossing is being constructed over it. The river remains more than decorative scenery. Its remembered behaviour calls for vigilance in design and safety. Aruni's earlier story involved embankments and flood

warning; Nand now faces questions of water, workers and construction simultaneously. The river's agency is represented not through a new flood actually occurring here, but through the potential force that an engineered structure must accommodate. Burhbā's appeal to flood memory gives an older environmental history a practical bearing upon the worksite. To introduce a fresh flood into the present sequence would go beyond the described events.

Aruni's Legacy: From Aspiration to Responsibility

Nand develops his father Aruni's ambition to build bridges and embankments. Aruni emphasised maintenance, knowledge of the river and collective care. His son adds the problem of preserving workers' names and guarding against administrative erasure. Inheritance is thus not mere imitation: Nand subjects his profession to an additional ethical demand. Working within a technical role, he recognises the danger that old injustices might recur under new forms of construction. The narrative refuses to assume that engineering progress automatically means social justice. What matters is whether skill becomes an ongoing practice of documentation, questioning and intervention. The father's work is extended rather than simply repeated.

Ananya's Active Influence in Her Physical Absence

The narrator recalls Ananya's teaching as the source of Nand's questioning gaze. Ananya is not presented as an active participant standing at this construction site; her educational influence appears through the way Nand observes his surroundings. This is a form of narrative presence through absence. An earlier character's agency operates within another character's later decision. Nand's present questions arise from his own professional experience, but the habit of looking critically was cultivated in the classroom. To attribute a direct intervention at the site to Ananya would be inaccurate, just as it would be to exclude her entirely from the history of Nand's awareness. Their contributions belong to different narrative moments.

Conflict with the Contractor: The Limits of the Result

Nand insists on additional precautions, enters each worker's name in his diary and argues with the contractor. These are definite actions. The chapter does not provide an official record proving that all particular safety rules were implemented, a complete wage statement or a penalty imposed on the contractor. Nor is Nand certain that his precautions will be sufficient. His initiative is therefore not a declaration of success but the acceptance of responsibility under conditions of risk. The uncertainty lends the action credibility. The story allows him to resist dangerous

practice without turning him into an all-powerful official capable of guaranteeing every worker's safety by an act of will.

"Guarding Names": The Further Development of the Diary

Nand's diary began after he learned of an erased worker. On this bridge project, the recording of every worker's name becomes a regular practice. An initially personal response to distress develops into a form of organised labour documentation. This transformation accords with the novel's recurring structure in which one incident generates a continuing social observance. Nevertheless, entry in Nand's diary does not itself establish wages, safety and legal remedies for everyone recorded. Naming is the beginning of visibility rather than the final accomplishment of justice. The book's central ritual acquires a practical form while retaining the limitations of any individual register.

The Bridge's Two Ends: Outward Connection and Ethical Division

The song warns that the bridge which joins people to the wider world may also allow a "new crocodile" to arrive. The same structure bears both the promise of mobility and the possibility of exploitation. Development becomes difficult to celebrate unconditionally. The joining of riverbanks is socially valuable, but the movement of strangers, trade, labour and potentially predatory networks complicates that value. The duality involves more than a contrast between a physical bridge and a symbolic one. Transport, worker registration and the anticipated criminal plot converge on the same site. The bridge is simultaneously infrastructure and an opening through which new relationships may become dangerous.

A Future Stage: The Narrator's Explicit Foreshadowing

The closing sentence states that this construction site will become the stage for a future "final chapter." It is exceptionally direct foreshadowing. The reader has been told where something decisive will happen, but not precisely what or how. Suspense shifts from the location of the event towards its identity and course. It would be wrong to read the sentence as evidence that the predicted disaster has already happened in this chapter. The stage is prepared; its decisive performance remains to come. The distinction between present construction and future event is part of the long narrative's deliberate distribution of information across its chapters.

The Song's Vigilance and the Prose's Unsecured Future

The song calls for guarding the bridge, keeping an account of names and remembering the floods. The prose depicts Nand acting cautiously, yet still unsure whether his actions will be enough. Together, these levels produce a more complex account of danger than either could alone. The song makes

a public rule memorable; the prose shows the insecurity of putting such a rule into practice. Vigilance is an ethical human action, not a guarantee against every later harm. This is a limit concerning narrative conduct rather than an abstract proof about knowledge. The difference between duty and complete security remains essential to Nand's development.

Overall Assessment: A Bridge and a Witness Still Under Construction

"Construction of the Bridge" brings the Kamala-Balan, exposed labourers, unidentified arrivals, a register of workers, arguments with the contractor and a future scene of crisis into one workplace. Nand is an assistant, not the supreme authority; the bridge is being built, not already opened; precautions have increased, but safety has not been finally demonstrated. These incompletions make the chapter a credible preparation for a later decisive event. The bridge joins more than two banks: narratively, it also connects present responsibility with an as-yet-unrevealed future. The figure of the witness, no less than the structure he helps build, remains unfinished.

Critical Section 88 | Original Chapter −13 — Gop Kumar's Compilation

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

Compilation in the Later Years of a Life

Gop Kumar has grown old; his hands tremble and his eyes have weakened. Long-continued archival labour is concentrated into the scene of a person gathering registers, loose pages, songs and modern records. No great external disaster or immediate criminal act drives this chapter. Its centre is the relationship between the ageing body of a collector and the immensity of the memory he is trying to preserve. A striking disproportion develops: materials gathered across centuries must be ordered within the finite remainder of one human life. That contrast makes Gop Kumar's dwindling time perceptible. His present work gives a physical form to a history too extensive to appear in one directly narrated scene.

An Ageing Body and the Extended Memory of Names

Gop Kumar's bodily powers decline even as his determination to bring the material together remains steady. His "trembling hands" stand against the ambition to weave history "into one thread." Physical capacity is limited; the work of remembrance reaches towards generations beyond him. Against the deaths and forgotten names accumulated earlier, documentary compilation becomes an instrument of communal survival. But archives do not confer bodily immortality on those they record, nor does the preservation of a page secure every dimension of someone's life. The visible exhaustion of the collector draws attention to these limits rather than simply celebrating the triumphant permanence of writing.

A Genealogy of Media from Yadavanand to the Modern Archive

The chapter brings Yadavanand's shadow register, Haripati the poet's manuscript, Gangadhar's printing press and digital records into one history of preservation. Each medium served a different social purpose in its time. Secrecy in the register, authority over expression in the poet's work, wider circulation through print and new capacities for digital storage cannot be described as the same process. Gop Kumar gathers these unequal materials without requiring one to cancel another. The chapter is thus not a simple triumphalist history in which each new technology renders its predecessor obsolete. Its subject is the interdependence of several documentary practices, their different origins, and their shared ability to preserve traces that might otherwise disappear.

Reconstructing the Sequence from Shell-and-Silver to the Present

The shell mistaken for silver, Hulasa's water burial, Sukhdev's unnamed death, Batuknath's fall, Ujjwal's dream and Chandrapal's account come together in Gop Kumar's imagination. This catalogue juxtaposes different historical periods, distinct positions of victimhood and culpability, and even events not yet fulfilled. It functions as a compressed self-remembrance of the enormous preceding narrative. Rather than retelling every episode, selected names and images awaken the reader's memory of the chapters in which they first appeared. The arrangement gives dispersed materials an emergent pattern. Yet the individuality and evidentiary status of each item must be preserved; a shared list does not transform all the characters into participants in a completed common incident.

A "Complete Picture" and One Remaining "Empty Place"

The compilation is repeatedly said to be coming together as a whole, almost complete. Yet the decisive scene identifies an empty place within that apparent completeness: the final chapter is still missing. The contradiction need not be dismissed as an accidental error. "Complete" may refer to the body of history available so far, while the course of future events remains open. The song celebrates gathering and completion; the prose continues to speak of nearness and unfinished work. Readers thus encounter both the attraction of totality and the actual incompleteness of lived time. The relation between those two conditions is the chapter's principal formal tension.

The "Final Chapter": A Deliberate Gap within the Story

Burhbā calls the approaching event the "final chapter." This is a character's anticipation, whereas the narrator describes Gop Kumar's present preparations. The collector is already assembling written pages but intentionally leaves a space for what has not yet happened. The empty place becomes a component of the plot. A future occurrence cannot truthfully be entered into the record as an accomplished event. Gop Kumar's patience represents an ethical discipline of writing: the desire for a complete story does not authorise the invention of its conclusion. The planned blank is therefore productive rather than merely deficient. It identifies an event still waiting to be witnessed.

Preparing the Inheritance of Memory for Nand

Burhbā says that Nand will need the whole preceding story ready to hand when a difficult moment comes. The compilation is thereby given a purpose beyond that of a passive museum-like collection. A young engineer may rely upon inherited accounts to recognise the nature of a new crisis. This is a direct narrative application of intergenerational

learning. Yet Nand has not in the present chapter received the entire compilation and used it to overcome that crisis. Its practical use is still anticipated, while Gop Kumar's labour is already underway. The difference matters because the narrative makes preparation real without treating future success as a completed fact.

Batuknath, Ujjwal and Chandrapal: Unequal Nodes

The narrator places these names within one emerging picture, but their narrative situations are distinct. Batuknath's decline has been described in current behaviour; Ujjwal remains associated with a foreboding concerning his future; Chandrapal has actually participated in financial transfers. A compilation can preserve the three without assigning them an identical degree of guilt or knowledge. Especially in Ujjwal's case, a predicted future must not be turned into an achieved outcome. The archival ethic lies in distinguishing different conditions of time and evidence while keeping their possible relationship visible. Weaving a thread through their stories does not erase the particularity of their conduct.

Compilation as Narrative Construction, Not Mere Collection

History does not arrange itself merely because pages are placed side by side. As Gop Kumar relates events, names and epochs, compilation becomes an act of narrative construction. The metaphor of "one picture" recognises the work of making relationships legible. Yadavanand's lists, the poet's text, printed accounts and newer documentary material acquire an order not given by physical accumulation alone. Gop Kumar is more than a clerk: he shapes the sequence through which the village may understand its history. Nonetheless, the text gives little sustained account of his editorial procedures, the checking of variant versions or the treatment of inconsistent sources. Construction of meaning is more fully expressed metaphorically than through specific scenes of textual criticism.

Narrator and Compiler: Two Different Perspectives

Gop Kumar increasingly feels that the scattered threads are coming together. Burhbā speaks more firmly about the approach of the decisive event still to occur. The compiler's sense of present completion and the long-lived witness's apprehension of the future remain different. The narrator places them in the same scene without itself showing that last event. Readers can share Gop Kumar's feeling of nearing an end while recognising its provisional character. The division of labour between the characters becomes apparent: one orders the dispersed past, and the other signals the prospect of an approaching crisis. Their roles cooperate, but they are not identical forms of knowledge.

The Debt of Time: Today's Archive and Tomorrow's Event

Gop Kumar's work is stretched in two directions: backwards towards centuries of materials and forwards towards an anticipated final occurrence. The present therefore becomes a threshold. He does not close history but keeps a place available for its continuation and for those who will read it. The phrase "time is short" applies both to bodily ageing and to the increasingly urgent movement of the plot. It is not only a decorative metaphor. Awareness of dwindling time prompts the collector to accelerate the organisation of his materials. The remaining days of an elderly person and the approaching narrative crisis produce a common emotional pressure, though they are different temporal processes.

The Song's Movement from Dispersal to Unity

The song repeatedly celebrates scattered names gathering together. The prose locates that celebration within the physical circumstances of trembling hands, an unfinished last chapter and a collector's lack of time. Reading the two levels together makes the achievement important without calling it complete. The song gives social dignity to Gop Kumar's patient work; the prose makes its human limits visible. Their relation illustrates a recurrent technique of the long narrative: the communal voice sings of completeness while individual practice struggles with the unfinished nature of history. Neither mode should erase the other. The narrative remains an ongoing task even when its lyric voice anticipates completion.

The Limit of Making Invisible Names Live Again

Looking at the accumulated names, Gop Kumar feels that he has brought people long dead back to life. The feeling is a metaphor of remembrance, not literal resurrection. It intensifies the moral imagination behind the older rituals of saving names. At the same time, the surviving record of a deceased person cannot stand in for the entirety of that person's experience. A precise reading can recognise the emotional force of the metaphor without turning the collector's interior experience into an objective event. Neither the strength of his feeling nor the amount of material assembled establishes that every gap in the historical record has been filled.

The Still-Unrevealed Convergence of the Final Event

Burhbā predicts that Nand's bridge, Chandrapal's account, Batuknath's court and the faraway tower will converge in one moment. Each element has already acquired its own narrative history. The present list gives them a prospective common point. Yet there is no joint meeting, decisive judicial ruling or climactic fraud enacted upon the bridge in this chapter. The

predicted convergence is increasingly legible, but its outcome remains withheld. This gap preserves the reader's desire to see how separate stories will intersect. Foreshadowing does substantial structural work without becoming a substitute for the event that it announces.

Overall Assessment: The Eve of Compilation

"Gop Kumar's Compilation" gathers an immense historical span into the exhausted body and persistent labour of one man. The movement from registers to digital records, the unequal situations of the emerging characters, Burhbā's forecast and the unfilled final place make the collection extensive but unfinished. Its principal achievement is to show how near a comprehensive arrangement of the known past has come, not to depict the final completed book. The archive does not take the place of the future incident; it waits for it. By drawing diverse names into one thread, Gop Kumar prepares the ground on which a later witness may recognise the crisis and tell its story.

Critical Section 89 | Original Chapter −12 — The Trembling of Channa Grove

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

A Collective Tremor in a Quiet Evening

The chapter opens with an evening on which all the trees of Channa Grove tremble together for no evident reason. The physical event lasts only a moment, but the community receives it as a warning charged with a long history. The peepal and surrounding trees form a unified narrative place. Earlier, the grove was a relatively stable setting for gatherings, memorial observances and rituals of naming; now the setting itself appears to act. The natural environment becomes a participant in narrative movement rather than mere scenery. The absence of a visible physical explanation is the centre of the mystery. It does not itself prove that no natural explanation could exist.

"Not a Leaf Was Moving": Stillness against Trembling

The prose says that the air was still and not a leaf moved, and then describes the whole grove shaking for an instant. The sequence depends upon a visual contrast: ordinary natural motion is absent, yet extraordinary collective movement occurs. If every description is taken as an assertion about precisely the same instant, a small inconsistency may seem to arise. Read instead as stillness interrupted by a sudden exceptional movement, the passage creates a startling pause. Criticism must preserve this linguistic subtlety rather than silently providing a scientific cause or prematurely claiming a demonstrated supernatural one. The narrative's force derives from the contrast between what appears normal and what suddenly exceeds expectation.

The Intimate Relation between the Grove and Burhbā's Life

Burhbā says that after the water burial his memory came to dwell in the grove's roots and leaves, and that its trembling is his own trembling. This statement belongs to the story's internal beliefs and to the character's interpretation of himself. Throughout the long narrative, Burhbā has served as an extraordinary witness beyond the span of an ordinary human life; here the grove seems to become the living body of that witnessing. The boundary between character and environment is unsettled. Yet the declared identification is not a claim from which external conclusions about botany can be drawn. Within the magical texture of the narrative, consciousness and landscape are poetically brought into relation.

The Ordinary Social Acceptance of Magical Realism

Villagers are frightened by the movement but do not immediately reject it as impossible. They remember earlier experiences and assemble beneath the peepal. Their response allows the uncanny occurrence to move between wonder and recognisable social practice. The gathering, lamps, recollections by elders and arrival of Ananya and Nand belong to the ordinary social world. The windless tremor adds a different, inexplicable register. Their coexistence gives the episode its magical-realist force. The narrator does not establish the phenomenon through a decisive natural-scientific investigation, yet it shows concrete changes in the villagers' behaviour. The marvel has consequences within their social experience even though its cause remains unknown.

An Elderly Woman's Memory of an Earlier Flood

A woman more than ninety years old remembers a similar tremor in her childhood, after which a great flood arrived. Her recollection gives the present experience a possible historical meaning. It does not establish an invariant rule that the present trembling must be followed by another flood. Burhbā's apprehension is of some "great event," not a definite prediction of an approaching inundation. The elderly woman's testimony opens one analogy among several possibilities. Its narrative work is to give fear a basis in remembered experience and to move the villagers towards vigilance. A personal recollection is not a universal causal law, and the text does not ask the reader to treat it as one.

The Joint Arrival of Ananya and Nand

Ananya and Nand rush to the grove and question Burhbā. Their earlier collaboration on the digital archive has already established them as a pair of active workers; now they become witnesses to an unsettling natural event. The lines of technical construction and inquiry-based education meet before an experience neither can immediately explain. Their response is questioning rather than instantaneous certainty. The scene maintains continuity with Nand's education in asking difficult questions and with the pair's present collaboration. Their lack of complete knowledge makes them credible participants in a moment of wonder, rather than omniscient interpreters whose technical training dissolves every uncertainty on contact.

Burhbā's Admission: "I Do Not Know"

Burhbā plainly says that he does not know what the event is, although he feels something momentous is near. The long-lived witness openly acknowledges the limits of his knowledge. This unsettles the easy portrait of him as someone who already knows every future occurrence. He

apprehends a possible scale of danger without identifying its cause, date or exact form. Such incompleteness keeps the story moving towards a future disclosure. A reader may recognise the narrative importance of Burhbā's intuition while resisting the inference that he has already seen the next event in full. His uncertainty is not a defect to be repaired; it is the chapter's explicit account of what can and cannot yet be known.

"As Though Taking a Deep Breath": The Language of Animate Nature

The grove is compared to a body taking one deep breath. The simile gives trees and leaves the sensory presence of a collective living character. Roots and foliage become figures for the community's feeling. Villagers respond as though the trembling constitutes a public signal. But a literary image of breathing and the empirical assertion of botanical consciousness are different claims. The narrator marks the relation with "as though." Its power is that of poetic resemblance rather than a necessary scientific demonstration. The grove's apparent animation translates a shared historical burden into the visible movement of a landscape long associated with human memory.

Concentrated Time: One Instant and Many Centuries

The tremor lasts a moment, but centuries of remembered experience gather around it. The grove's long existence, Burhbā's post-burial life and the older woman's recollections of childhood floods return within one evening. An immense narrative duration is compressed into a tiny physical incident. Readers perceive not simply a shaking grove but its resonance with previous inundations, deaths and collective apprehensions. Such temporal concentration gives the coming crisis an epic weight even though no present damage has been shown. The magnitude resides in the history attached to the moment, not in the measurable extent of the motion itself.

Villagers Gathering: The Social Consequence of a Sign

After the tremor, frightened villagers assemble at the peepal. The unusual experience thus produces a definite communal action. The familiar ritual setting becomes the centre of an evening vigil, with lamps, quiet conversations among women and the movement of people towards a shared place. Memories of older warnings influence their present decisions. Whether the tremor causes or reliably predicts the future crisis remains unknown, but its immediate influence on the village's behaviour is narrated as an event. Natural experience becomes socially consequential. The chapter can therefore analyse the effects of belief without first resolving the independent physical cause of the phenomenon.

Lamplight and Low Voices

At the close, lamps remain alight, women speak quietly, and Nand and Ananya wait beneath the trees. This combination of muted sound and limited illumination replaces rapid action with suspended expectation. The narrative depicts no disaster taking place during the vigil. Its people are waiting for an event they cannot identify. The murmured voices carry both fear and a sense of communal support. Lamplight does not remove uncertainty; it creates a human space in which uncertainty can be borne collectively. The concluding image is not resolution but time held open. This arrested movement is essential to the chapter's emotional architecture.

The Grove's Warning and the Absence of Scientific Certainty

The narrator says that the trembling occurred "without any clear cause." This is an account of an unexplained phenomenon within the story, not a demonstration that all natural laws have failed. Burhbā's intuition likewise has social and narrative significance without constituting a verified system for predicting earthquakes or other disasters. Narratological analysis should ask how the belief system functions inside the fiction instead of automatically treating it as an external scientific report. The passage intensifies fear by means of personal and communal interpretation. Its cause remains unspecified, and that distinction must survive even an appreciative reading of its uncanny effects.

The Song's Confident Command and the Prose's Unknowing Vigil

The folk song declares that the grove trembled, that a momentous occurrence is near and that everyone must stay awake. The main prose does show fear and wakefulness, but it does not identify the event to come. The two levels consequently do not provide the same kind of outcome. The lyric issues a collective command and offers a sense of directional certainty; the prose holds people within an unanswered question. Their coexistence produces the episode's emotional climax. A critical reader must resist allowing the lyric's emphatic forecasting to supply an event that the prose has not narrated. Preparation is certain; the future remains unknown.

Earlier Functions of the Grove and Their Reconfiguration

Channa Grove has already been associated with memorial ceremonies, women's night assemblies, tree planting and water protection. Now, by seeming to tremble of its own accord, it acquires the role of an active sign within the narrative world. A single place repeatedly changes function: a precinct of remembrance, a space for communal justice, a foundation for environmental care and finally a sign of approaching change. The transformation shows that location is not a fixed ornament in this novel

but a structure with something like character and duration. Its apparent action moves the grove from being an archive of events towards becoming a possible initiator of narrative movement.

Collective Fear and the Silence surrounding Social Difference

Villagers gather as a community, but the chapter does not distinguish the separate responses of every neighbourhood, caste, class or household. A collective pronoun temporarily pushes social difference into the background. Earlier parts of the long novel have described particular experiences of marginalised groups; here the village is shaped as one emotional body. The method produces an expansive shared apprehension, but affords little room for divergent private reactions. This is not a celebration of social unity already proved by an equal outcome. It is a moment of common anxiety whose possible unequal effects have not yet been narrated. Criticism can identify the limits of focalisation without inventing exclusions or subsequent harm.

Overall Assessment: The Environment Becomes a Sign

"The Trembling of Channa Grove" is physically brief, temporally expansive and symbolically dense. The unexplained movement of trees in still air, an old woman's memory of flooding, Burhbā's intuition qualified by ignorance, Ananya and Nand's questioning, and a night of communal waiting combine to produce the atmosphere of an impending event. The chapter does not depict the future catastrophe. It depicts the conditions under which that catastrophe is anticipated. By animating the landscape, it gives place the force of a witnessing body. The literary power of this mystery is best understood while maintaining the necessary difference between memory, sign and a future outcome not yet revealed.

Critical Section 90 | Original Chapter −11 — Burhbā's Final Blessing

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Word “Final” as Advance Narrative Information

The title calls Burhbā's blessing “final”, although the principal prose narrates neither his death nor an actual last sight of him. “Final” is therefore a word that directs the reader's expectation towards a possible future rather than a report of an already concluded life. By introducing a sense of closure before the event, the narrative concentrates on a fragile moment in which the witness of innumerable years seeks to place his burden in the hands of a successor. Against the title's apparent certainty, the prose uses comparisons such as “like a farewell” and “like a transfer of responsibility”. Such formulations preserve possibility. Treating them as a factual announcement of Burhbā's death would eliminate the interval that the text deliberately leaves open.

From the Grove's Trembling to the Following Night

Chapter [−12] describes the trembling of the entire Channa Grove and the villagers' assembly, without disclosing a cause. On the following night Burhbā summons Nand alone. The sequence is important: a collective apprehension is immediately followed by a private act of transmission. The new chapter does not furnish the missing explanation for the grove's movement. Instead, it changes the form of the warning, converting a sign experienced by the community into a possible personal obligation for a young man. Readers are shown the psychological and ethical consequence of an anticipated event before that event has occurred. The arrangement therefore provides continuity while retaining the causal uncertainty and impending danger established by the previous scene.

One Lamp and the Concentration of the Scene

Only a single lamp burns beneath the peepal tree. Compared with the village's recent communal gathering, this scene is restricted in illumination, number of participants and immediate duration. The lamp is not merely decorative atmosphere: its small circle of light establishes the narrow visual and dramatic field in which the conversation unfolds. Readers attend to Burhbā and Nand while the larger village, physically absent, persists through the memories they invoke. A brief encounter carries a history extending across centuries. This contrast produces the chapter's density: limited place, momentary action and an immense recalled past. The lamp illuminates the exchange without supplying

knowledge of the undisclosed disaster, and its intimate light makes the transfer of historical responsibility perceptible.

Responsibility Gradually Formed Through Dialogue

The order of the exchange is itself significant. Burhbā first identifies Nand as an inheritor who may have to face an approaching trial. Nand then asks what he must do. The response does not provide an operational list or describe a particular future accident; it offers the resources of remembrance and courage. The dialogue prepares a character rather than solving an event. By withholding a prescribed action, the narrator allows Nand's response to unforeseen conditions to remain an open question. His developing responsibility comes through listening and asking rather than the automatic fulfilment of a prophecy. The spaces left in the exchange are essential to the suspense leading into the following chapter.

Nand's Limited Knowledge and the Reader's Additional Fear

Nand knows Burhbā's inherited stories but does not know the nature of the approaching crisis. Readers also lack the accident's particulars, although they can combine the trembling in [–12] with the word "final" in the present title and form a sharper apprehension. They are not made omniscient; their advantage consists in connecting narrative signs. Nand's questioning and subsequent silence make this shared state of incomplete knowledge humanly credible. Rather than reveal the calamity prematurely, the narrative constructs an emotional prehistory for it. When later events occur, the blessing can return as remembered speech, and its significance will arise from the earlier limitation of knowledge as much as from its consoling words.

The Work of a Genealogical Form of Address

Burhbā addresses Nand by a genealogical phrase, calling him Aruni's grandson. The relationship is more than an item of family identification. It summons Nand's engineering work, Aruni's construction of embankments and the village's long struggles with water into a single present address. Generational time is compressed into a few words. Yet descent cannot prove that the inheritor will become an adequate witness or act rightly during the coming trial. Nand will have to decide for himself. The text thus preserves tension between the prestige and expectations of ancestry and the responsibility exercised through individual action. The genealogical term establishes continuity without closing the question of what its bearer will ultimately do.

Recalling Names: From Recorded Memory to Living Companionship

Burhbā invokes Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Gauri and Sunayanā as presences that can strengthen Nand's courage. Lives separated by historical periods are assembled in a brief sequence of names, returning the novel's past to the young man's moral imagination. The passage does not say that these people bodily return to the meeting or appear as independently acting spirits. The promise that they will "stand behind" him gives remembered lives the form of ethical companionship. A sound reading therefore distinguishes figurative support from the literal re-entry of former characters. The force of the naming lies in its capacity to make past resistance available as a resource for present decisions while preserving the different historical circumstances of those recalled.

The Repetition of "You Will Not Be Alone"

Burhbā's assurance that Nand will not be alone is the chapter's principal audible refrain. First it is spoken in the external dialogue; later it reverberates through Nand's sleepless night. The same sentence passes from one person's voice into another person's memory. Its repetition is therefore a transformation of the medium that carries it rather than simply a duplication of meaning. A heard utterance becomes an inward resource that may influence an action still to come. The chapter follows the retention of speech more closely than the unfolding of external events. This emphasis belongs to the long narrative's oral and intergenerational structure, in which words survive their original occasions through renewed listening and recollection.

The Blessing's Double Character: Consolation and Warning

A blessing normally conveys goodwill and the hope of welfare. Here it is accompanied by explicit fear: references to a great test and a dark hour prevent the words from becoming a simple celebration. This tension gives the exchange its distinctive effect. Nand is not made implausibly fearless or guaranteed safety; he is encouraged to endure even in the presence of fear. The promised support is moral rather than a detailed defence against an identified danger. Accordingly, the chapter connects the approaching tragedy to earlier expectations without announcing the tragedy's result in advance. Consolation and foreboding coexist. Their union makes the blessing a complicated preparation for suffering rather than an assurance that suffering can no longer occur.

The Song's Seed and the Prose's Burden

The opening song compares the blessing to a seed that will flower after many years. In the prose Burhbā appears to place the burden of centuries upon Nand's shoulders. These are not identical images. A seed suggests

growth and a future capacity to flourish; a burden conveys the weight of responsibility and the difficulty of receiving it. The folk song inclines towards the certainty of successful germination, whereas the prose retains Nand's lack of knowledge and the discomfort of acceptance. Reading both images together reveals two different experiences of the same transmission. Merging them into a single uncomplicated assertion of future success would weaken both the song's hope and the dialogue's unease.

"Burhbā Has Gone" in the Song and the Prose's Actual Limits

The folk song contains a line to the effect that Burhbā has gone while his blessing remains. The prose, however, ends with Burhbā sending Nand away from the peepal tree; it does not report his death or physical departure. Writing a definite death scene or permanent farewell into this chapter would exceed the source. The song compresses narrative time and can speak of a possible future ending as an already felt loss. Its temporality is therefore partly independent of the principal prose. The long emotional consequence of an event may be voiced before its chronological occurrence. Preserving this distinction explains the song's elegiac force without confusing poetic anticipation with narrated fact.

Nand's Silent Acceptance and His Agency

Nand accepts the burden without saying no, but the text gives neither a formal oath nor a written declaration of agreement. His agency is expressed more quietly: he asks a question, listens, undergoes an inward change and remains awake through the night. The narrative depicts the emergence of responsibility before heroic action in the external world. Even this acceptance does not prove that every later decision will be correct. A character's development must still be tested against particular events. The importance of the silence lies in its responsiveness to remembered suffering and prospective duty, not in an irrevocable guarantee of success. The episode makes moral formation an observable narrative process while leaving its eventual results undecided.

Burhbā's Longevity and His Narrative Authority

Burhbā's words acquire weight from his experience of many successive generations. He functions not simply as a grandfatherly elder but as one of the principal axes of narrative time. Nevertheless, the prose does not declare his knowledge to be complete foresight. Expressions of what seems likely and what is approaching still admit uncertainty. His authority arises from centuries of remembered encounters and the confidence of those who listen, not from absolutely certain knowledge of every future detail. This difference prevents the extraordinary witness from dissolving into divine omniscience. His unusually long life serves the literary organisation

of collective memory while his inability to specify the crisis preserves recognisably human limits of anticipation.

The Following Day: Foreshadowing at the Chapter's End

The closing paragraph says that Nand does not know how the following day will change the village's life. Here the narrator briefly looks beyond the character's immediate knowledge and establishes an expectation of rupture. The number of people affected, the kind of disaster and the identity of its central victim are still withheld. This measured advance information opens the narrative door to [–10], "The First Splash at the Bridge". It directs the reader towards a future event rather than merely providing a poignant ending to the blessing. The suspense depends on the precise balance between what is foretold and what is not. A subsequent reading can see the construction of this threshold without pretending that the preceding chapter already contained the event itself.

The Communal Meaning of a Private Promise

Burhbā calls Nand to a private meeting, yet his speech carries the dead, the dispossessed, earlier resistance and the history of naming into that intimacy. A personal conversation thus becomes a transmission of collective inheritance. There is no public assembly voting on a successor and no legal appointment. Instead, one person's consciousness becomes a prospective bearer of communal testimony. This form has strength and limitation. It may keep the ritual of remembrance alive in Nand's decisions, but it also places the narrative emphasis on an individual's internal acceptance rather than the deliberation of the whole community. The chapter must therefore be read as a concentrated ethical transfer, not as proof that every collective obligation has been institutionally settled.

Overall Narratological Assessment

"Burhbā's Final Blessing" is a transition rich in emotional meaning rather than in external events. One lamp, the narrow peepal setting, two voices, repeated names and the anticipation of the following day form an inner prelude to a calamity not yet described. Its chief achievement is to present the making of a witness as a readiness to carry other people's histories before the witness can know what must next be witnessed. The scene's limited action gives unusual weight to its verbal rhythm and ancestral memories. Read without cancelling the prose's uncertainty, the blessing remains an intricate conjunction of affection, apprehension, duty and unresolved future time.

Critical Section 91 | Original Chapter −10 — The First Splash at the Bridge

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From Foreshadowing to the Moment of an Actual Accident

In [−11], the impending "dark hour" was only indicated; in [−10] the warning acquires a concrete event at the bridge-construction site. The earlier fear is given a location, a night, exhausted labourers, insufficient light and inadequate safety measures. This conversion from apprehension to occurrence is a decisive structural turn in the long novel. Yet the prose does not furnish a complete technical investigation into the accident's causes. Its immediacy lies in the unsafe conditions, the force of the rain-swollen river and Nand's perception of what unfolds. A need for subsequent inquiry follows naturally from the gaps in what the scene can establish. The event is no longer hypothetical, but the evidence surrounding it remains incomplete.

Moonless Night and the Limits of Visibility

There is no moon on the night of the accident. The river runs fiercely with rainwater, and the workers labour in exhaustion under inadequate illumination. These details are more than atmospheric conventions. They impose material limits on sight, access to help and the recognition of a person in danger. Even though Nand is present, he cannot see everything; neither the worker's face nor his name becomes clear. Darkness increases pathos while also withholding information. The missing identity furnishes the central question of the later investigation rather than merely an ornamental mystery. The scene's sensory restriction is therefore integral to the plot's sequence of knowledge: an accident can be witnessed without the victim becoming identifiable.

"Splash": The Centrality of an Audible Event

The sound of the worker's fall is compressed into one word: "splash". According to the narrative, the sound travels as far as the nearest settlement, yet the worker's name does not travel with it. The contrast between the reach of noise and the absence of identity produces the episode's particular sorrow. Many can hear that something has happened without knowing to whom it happened. The title makes an acoustic instant the memorial mark of the chapter. The reader retains the sound while the protagonist undertakes the harder search for a missing name. The incident thereby links hearing, social recognition and the failure of existing records within a single moment of narrative concentration.

A Directly Narrated Fall and an Unknown Name

The original prose explicitly describes the fallen labourer as someone "whose name is still unclear". Nand reaches out and calls for a name, but finds neither the hand nor the name he seeks. This limitation must remain intact. The text does not subsequently identify the worker with certainty in this scene, and it does not give a full account of the eventual discovery of the body or final outcome. What it establishes is the ethical obligation towards an unidentified person. The novel separates the imperative to help or remember someone from the process of securing that person's identity. Even the distinction between confirmed death and disappearance in the floodwater requires care. The scene's incompleteness is not a licence to supply an imagined identification.

The Speed and Failure of Nand's Rescue Attempt

As soon as the worker falls, Nand rushes to help and jumps into the water. His action demonstrates immediate initiative and a willingness to expose himself to danger. The failure to reach the person does not, by itself, establish a moral failure by the rescuer; darkness and the force of the current are direct obstacles. Nor does an individual act of courage settle questions about the construction site's safety arrangements. The scene juxtaposes an engineer's personal resolve with deficiencies belonging to a wider system of labour and supervision. Its force depends on retaining both levels. To celebrate Nand's courage while erasing structural negligence, or to convert his unsuccessful attempt into personal blame, would distort the narrative's actual conflict.

Public Knowledge of the Accident and Private Grief

The splash is heard in the nearby settlement, but after the attempt Nand returns to the peepal tree shaken and in tears. This movement converts a publicly audible signal into private mourning. The chapter does not stage the extensive reactions of a village crowd; its narrative focus remains upon Nand's wet body, the water dripping from him and his grief. The emotional movement is brief in narrated time but consequential for the protagonist's understanding of his work. What has been heard by others as a sound becomes, in his memory, a demand for a record. The spatial transition from construction site to peepal also carries an accident out of the domain of technical work into that of communal responsibility.

River Water and Tears as Parallel Images

The narrator brings together river water running from Nand's body and tears falling from his eyes. An external calamity and an internal state of suffering are joined through the same liquid imagery. Water does not cease to be the dangerous physical current that obstructed rescue, but it also

becomes part of the character's felt experience. The great crocodile metaphor can resonate in this scene without any literal crocodile being shown attacking the worker. Its symbolic force comes from the context of unsafe labour and violent water, not from replacing those facts. The image is most effective when its two dimensions remain legible: the material danger that Nand has confronted and the grief that danger leaves within him.

Burhbā's Response and the Transfer of Blame

Burhbā tells Nand that failing to save the labourer is not his personal fault. He points instead to darkness, the current and a system that treats workers as numbers. This is an utterance by a character, not the findings of an independent administrative inquiry. Narratively, it redirects Nand's guilt towards a broader question of labour's invisibility. The individual catastrophe becomes connected to practices of counting workers without recognising persons. Retaining the status of Burhbā's words prevents a moral interpretation from being mistaken for a legal determination of responsibility. The speech matters because it makes structural conditions thinkable at the point when Nand is most vulnerable to treating the entire tragedy as his own failure.

"Two Deaths": The Construction of Social Oblivion

Burhbā warns that a worker whose name is not preserved will die twice. The phrase creates two distinct levels: physical loss and subsequent disappearance from collective memory. The metaphor's sharpness lies in the differing scope for human action. The first may already have escaped the witnesses' control; the second can still be resisted by recovering and recording a person's identity. This moral demand informs Nand's later diary. Yet memorialisation is not the same as securing compensation, establishing safety or obtaining accountability for surviving relatives. A full criticism must hold those further questions open rather than treating the act of writing a name as the complete remedy for harm. The phrase establishes the urgency of remembrance and its limits simultaneously.

The Folk Song's Crocodile and the Prose's Actual Accident

The folk song confidently says that a crocodile took the worker's body. In the prose of the accident itself, the narrated circumstances are a fierce river current, an unnamed person falling into water and Nand's attempt to rescue him. No directly witnessed attack by an actual crocodile is described. Collapsing the difference would turn an inherited mythic image into an incorrect physical account of the incident. In the song, the crocodile carries the older language of water's destructive power. The prose is concerned with unsafe construction conditions and the absence of a

reliable personal identity. Both levels contribute to the chapter's meaning, but they do not make the same factual assertion. Their distinction is indispensable to an accurate translation and narratological reading.

The Temporal Complexity of "First"

The chapter is called the "first splash" although numerous earlier chapters have described water burial, flooding and drowning. "First" cannot therefore mean the village's first water-related catastrophe. Its frame is narrower: the new bridge site, Nand's personal experience as a witness and the emerging writing project called The Account of the Splash. The word marks the beginning of a particular moral and narrative undertaking, not the commencement of the novel's roughly twelve-century history. This local qualification allows the title to be meaningful without cancelling earlier crises. It also indicates how long narratives can give a recurrent event a new "first" by changing the observer, institutional setting and future significance of the event.

The Diary's First Page Revisited: A Temporal Tension

In Chapter [−20], Nand had already written an inherited saying on the first page of his diary. After the accident, the present chapter again refers to the first page and describes the same saying being written there. The repetition may be understood as a change in remembrance: what was first entered as a future obligation now gains urgency from an actual loss. Nevertheless, the exact physical chronology of the diary's first page is not made unambiguous by the text. This repetition carries a small but real temporal tension. Criticism should register the ambiguity rather than quietly alter the earlier entry or invent a second notebook. The renewed writing is emotionally intelligible even while the object's literal sequence remains incompletely specified.

An Endless List and the Expansion of the Plot

Nand resolves to seek not only this worker's name but also the names of others like him. A single incident thus opens into a plural undertaking. The particular accident has occurred, but the search it generates has not been completed. This is a characteristic means by which the novel extends its narrative: one obscured life reveals a wider pattern of nameless labour and social exclusion. The Account of the Splash thereby promises to become more than a diary of grief. It is conceived as an archive resisting the systematic disappearance of workers from public recognition. The extent of the future list is not yet known, and the commitment to search must not be misrepresented as a list already compiled.

Construction Site and Peepal: Two Ethical Locations

The bridge site belongs to modern development, contracting, labour and risk. The peepal tree is a locus of witnessing, remembrance and ethical conversation. Nand links these locations through his own movement: he brings the river's water back upon his body and receives an instruction that sends him towards further accounting for the accident. This journey advances the plot as well as its symbolic design. The peepal is not an office of judicial investigation, and the bridge is not a ritual assembly ground. The protagonist's responsibility arises in the interval between them. Each place provides what the other lacks: the dangerous immediacy of work and the historical vocabulary through which neglect can be recognised.

Absence of a Body or Identity as an Inherited Question

The unnamed worker's actual name remains unavailable at the end of the prose. That absence should not be treated solely as a device for evoking sentimental sorrow. It draws attention to failures of a recording system in which the existence of a worker has not been adequately secured. By refusing to supply the missing name, the narrative establishes why the next chapter's investigation is necessary. The critic should not replace this absence with an invented death certificate, family history or later discovery of a body. The unresolved question gives Nand a task and gives the reader a reason to expect documentation. Mourning becomes inseparable from the demand to know who has been lost.

Overall Assessment: From Sound to Document

"The First Splash at the Bridge" is a highly concentrated episode in which a long sequence of warnings becomes an instant of audible violence. Nand's unsuccessful rescue, Burhbā's appeal to preserve names, the unknown labourer and the renewed diary turn a single accident into an ongoing inquiry. Its most urgent ethical question is not simply "Which crocodile caused the fall?" but "Who was the person who fell?" The distinction between the prose's unresolved knowledge and the song's confident metaphor keeps both grief and investigation active. By the end, the sound of water has begun to demand a document, and personal shock has become the beginning of a wider witnessing practice.

Critical Section 92 | Original Chapter −9 — The Beginning of the Investigation

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From an Accident Scene to an Investigative Narrative

The fall at the bridge was rendered as an intense scene in [−10]. Chapter [−9] enters the documentary search begun after it. Nand asks the contractor for papers, examines the attendance register and questions fellow workers. The dominant verbs change from running and leaping to observing, questioning and comparing. This shift in tempo is not simply a pause after the tragedy: it expands the narrative into the procedures of an investigation. The lament over an unnamed labourer becomes a search for an identifiable person. The genre of the narrative itself changes, moving from immediate bodily danger to the gathering and interpretation of clues. The missing worker's name remains the inquiry's focus, not an answer already available to the reader.

The Absence of the Real Name as the Initial Mystery

Nand discovers that the worker had been employed under a false name and a false age. This information deepens the earlier uncertainty. In [−10] the name was unclear; here the space in which the authentic name should appear has already been occupied by inaccurate entries. Yet the narrator does not instantly reveal the true identity. Instead, evidence begins to accumulate around a persistent vacancy. The desire to recover a name develops from Nand's individual grief into the motivating force of an investigative plot. The distinction matters: this is not a case in which no records exist at all, but one in which the existing records may actively obstruct the recognition of the person they purport to describe.

The Attendance Register: A Gap Between Number and Person

An attendance register should connect workers to the written arrangements of an employer or administrative authority. Here its entries cannot be trusted as straightforward routes to the persons concerned, because the recorded name and age are false. The irony does not justify a blanket rejection of documents. Rather, it creates a problem about their reliability and the need to compare different forms of information. Fellow workers' recollections and the formal register possess different strengths and limitations. The narrative acquires tension by asking what each source can actually disclose. Its argument is not that every sheet of paper is fraudulent, but that written inclusion can conceal the living person's

identity when a record becomes detached from the individual it ought to represent.

"Losing One's Name While Still Alive"

The prose suggests that the labourer seems to have lost his name somewhere while he was still living. This comparison directs attention to the erasure of identity before the accident. The worker's disappearance from recognisable records is therefore not only a possible consequence of death or submersion. The labour system had already admitted false identifying information. The metaphor performs a definite narrative function: the threat of posthumous oblivion is preceded by a form of documentary anonymity during life. Nonetheless, the chapter does not explain why the labourer was registered under a false name. Poverty, coercion, concealment or administrative convenience cannot be asserted as particular causes without textual support. The uncertainty belongs to the investigation itself.

Three Irregularities in the Contractor's Papers

The original prose places three concerns in sequence: the construction company's records are unclear; the workers' names do not appear to be genuine; and money appears to move over substantial distances. Their juxtaposition invites the reader to suspect a larger arrangement. Yet unclear records do not, by themselves, prove which individual has committed an offence. The narration advances from the identity of one lost worker towards broader institutional relationships by organising disparate irregularities as clues. This series is an important hinge in the plot. It supplies a reason for the inquiry into labour records to intersect with an inquiry into finance. The combination strengthens suspicion without resolving responsibility or the ultimate direction of the funds.

Satyavrat's Arrival: A Second Investigative Perspective

Satyavrat happens to encounter the construction company's banking connections. His inquiry does not begin as a subordinate part of Nand's search: it brings a history of independent observation of suspicious transactions. Through his arrival, the story moves beyond the bridge and gains access to records from another institution. Satyavrat communicates what he has been following, allowing two bodies of incomplete knowledge to meet. The narrator does not suddenly produce an all-seeing investigation agency that has solved the case from above. Instead, one character's partial view is enlarged by another's, giving the management and circulation of information new complexity. Their encounter is a means of organising investigation, not the discovery of a completed criminal dossier.

The Trail of a Name and the Trail of Money

Satyavrat expresses their distinct tasks succinctly: Nand is looking for the worker's name; he is looking for the route of the money. These two paths provide the chapter's primary structural device. One starts with personal existence and social recognition, the other with the movement of funds and institutional accounts. The breadth and fragmentation of the suspected operation make both views necessary. Their decision to work together does not establish that the two trails have already reached the same person or criminal organiser. A joint investigation has begun; its decisive common finding remains ahead. Keeping the two inquiries analytically distinct prevents cooperation from being confused with proof, and gives the future conjunction of their discoveries a specific narrative purpose.

The Peepal Dialogue and the Communal Meaning of Investigation

After meeting Satyavrat, Nand goes to Burhbā beneath the peepal tree. The tree is not transformed into an investigative office; it remains a place for ethical orientation and the recollection of communal history. Burhbā urges the two investigators to join their threads and warns that their possible opponent may be powerful. The dialogue gives a larger moral significance to their separate searches without supplying a definite culprit or a full financial map. The factual labour of verification remains with Nand and Satyavrat. Burhbā names the risks and the value of proceeding. The chapter therefore connects modern procedures of inquiry to inherited practices of witnessing, while preserving the difference between ethical encouragement and discovered evidence.

Digging a Channel: A Folk Image of Investigative Labour

The folk song likens an investigation to digging a water channel: first comes mud, then clear water. The image moves downwards, into the soil, instead of relying entirely upon the familiar figure of bringing something into the light. Truth is not already spread across the surface; it requires labour, depth and patience. Nand's requests for records and his questioning of other workers give the metaphor concrete narrative correlates. Its insistence upon work is especially fitting in a chapter concerned with the obscured life of a labourer. Yet the clarity promised at the end of the song is not attained in the prose at this stage. The image establishes a method and an aspiration rather than announcing the verified completion of the search.

The Song's Mud and the Prose's Continuing Uncertainty

The song moves confidently from muddy water to transparency and the finding of truth. The prose concludes only that the suspected network's

shape is becoming clear gradually. This difference can be read as the distinction between a communal, result-oriented expression of hope and a narrative of step-by-step inquiry. If the song's optimism were simply transferred into the account of events, the chapters devoted to later investigation would appear superfluous. The critical task is to keep the song's moral confidence visible without claiming that its promised end has already occurred. The prose insists on incomplete information, difficult comparison and delayed verification. The interplay of the two modes makes the process of discovery meaningful rather than redundant.

The Narrator's Control of Additional Information

Through Nand, the reader learns of false names; through Satyavrat, of questionable financial movements; through Burhbā, of the possibility of a powerful adversary. No character sees the entire arrangement. The narrator nevertheless ends by placing the drowned worker at one end of an enormous web and a glass tower across the sea at the other. This panoramic formulation gives the reader an anticipatory sense of totality before the characters possess the supporting detail. The distribution of knowledge is therefore deliberately uneven. It stimulates the excitement of investigation while retaining a distance between narrated suggestion and substantiated linkage. A careful reading identifies the narrator's broad horizon without retroactively attributing comprehensive knowledge to Nand or Satyavrat.

The Distant Tower and the Enlargement of Scale

The narrative stretches, by implication, from one bridge near Garh Narikel to a glass tower overseas. A local worker's uncertain fate comes to be considered alongside the possibility of a global financial network. The enlargement is created by a suspected chain of transactions and the language of comparison, not by Nand's actual journey abroad. Nor is an international suspect arrested in the present chapter. Recognising these limits makes the novel's treatment of distance more coherent. Its scope can expand enormously without altering the immediate location of the investigation. The distant tower operates as a possible end point in the story's informational geography while the hard work of tracing money and names remains rooted in local documents.

The Narrative Function of “By Chance”

The construction company's banking connection comes to Satyavrat's attention “by chance”. In a long novel with many separate strands, coincidence can serve as a bridge between previously developed storylines. Here it allows years of accumulated banking observations to enter a relevant contemporary inquiry without an extended introductory sequence. Coincidence also carries a potential cost: were every connection

repeatedly provided through chance, the effort of the characters could lose credibility. In this case, however, coincidence initiates contact; it does not complete the verification. Nand and Satyavrat must still investigate. The episode thus uses a convenient convergence to produce a new field of action rather than to substitute sudden omniscience for the labour of inquiry.

The Silent Victim and the Crisis of Representation

The worker's real name remains obscured, and his own voice while alive is not directly represented at the centre of the chapter. His story is reconstructed through Nand, fellow labourers, a contractor's entries and banking records. This arrangement raises an ethical question: the person for whom the inquiry is being conducted cannot speak for himself within it. The novel makes the responsibility of witnessing particularly acute through that absence. Criticism should not invent his words, family circumstances or intentions to fill the gap. The vacancy is itself a significant object of analysis. It reveals the difference between representing an injured person responsibly and claiming access to a life that the narrative has not made available.

A Collective Investigation and Distinct Individual Duties

Nand and Satyavrat begin to work together without relinquishing their separate questions. Their cooperation does not collapse the trail of the name into that of the money. Instead, it makes two forms of evidence mutually necessary. In this respect the investigation becomes a modern continuation of older village practices of collective work. Neither participant's contribution is sufficient in isolation. The incomplete division of knowledge opens the prospect of future accusation, public documentation, judicial engagement and further scrutiny. The chapter's achievement is therefore organisational before it is conclusive. It establishes a credible arrangement for pursuing a complicated story and allows particular characters to retain responsibility for the fields in which they can actually contribute.

Overall Assessment: From One Sound to Two Records

"The Beginning of the Investigation" turns the ethical uncertainty following the accident into an organised search. The worker's false identity, the contractor's ambiguous documentation, Satyavrat's banking information and Burhbā's counsel enlarge the original question. Who was the worker? Along what path did the money move? How might those two trajectories intersect? The folk song clothes investigation in the familiar imagery of digging, patience and eventual clear water; the prose leaves results incomplete. The chapter's distinctive accomplishment is not a final solution but the creation of a practical and narratively credible search

capable of pursuing one. A single audible loss has thus generated two developing archives of evidence.

Critical Section 93 | Original Chapter −8 — The Evidence Comes to Light

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From a Confidential Notebook to a Public Narrative

In [−31], Satyavrat recorded banking details privately; in [−19], he approached a decision to speak; in [−8], he finally takes the accumulated dates, accounts and transactions to a trustworthy journalist and an investigative agency. A development spread across many chapters is concentrated in this decisive transfer. Information leaves private custody and enters institutions that can bring it before the public. Yet publication, criminal punishment and complete justice are not interchangeable stages. Making evidence available opens another process rather than concluding it. The novel's long preparation therefore receives a definite event without dissolving all its remaining questions. The narrative threshold is the movement of a record from guarded silence into possible public accountability.

Gop Kumar's Assistance: Compilation Meets Disclosure

Satyavrat releases the material with Gop Kumar's help. This brief action joins two formerly developing lines: the banking record of financial movements and the village's long practice of gathering historical documents. Gop Kumar is more than a respected elder whose approval lends prestige; the prose presents him as a participant in moving information into circulation. It does not, however, give a detailed account of how many pages he selected, how conflicting entries were handled or what legal strategy was employed. The significance of the act lies in the joining of archival labour to public disclosure. Criticism can recognise the cooperation without constructing an unseen editorial or legal procedure that the source has not narrated.

Three Settings of Disclosure: Notebook, Journalism and Investigation

The information passes across three different sites of narration and authority: Satyavrat's private notebook, the journalist's public presentation and the investigative agency's prospective formal action. Their functions differ. The notebook allows a witness to retain detailed observations; news reporting makes a story publicly visible; institutional investigation may enable further proceedings. The chapter describes a transfer through these stages, not their automatic equivalence. News publication is not by itself an adjudicated criminal fact, and the delivery of material to an agency is not an announcement of an arrest. Clarifying the stages preserves the exact

character of the breakthrough. The narrative makes a formerly concealed pattern discussable while leaving much of the institutional process ahead.

Different Names Brought Into One Picture

The narrator now juxtaposes Ujjwal Jha's indebted position, Batuknath's legal work, Chandrapal's account and the overseas connections associated with Lau Kin-hung. Their assembly causes readers to revisit strands that had appeared separately. It is not merely a cast list: earlier fragments acquire new possible relations within a single alarming configuration. Nevertheless, these people do not occupy equivalent evidentiary or moral positions. A debtor, a lawyer whose conduct has declined, an account holder and a person discussed in reports cannot all be assigned the same responsibility simply because their names appear together. The narrative picture is a synthesis of suspected connections, not an undifferentiated conviction of its every component. The critical account must preserve the differences it brings together.

Limits of Knowledge About Ujjwal's Position

Ujjwal's birth and Burhbā's troubled vision were narrated in [—34]. The present chapter says he is in debt, but offers no elaborate scene of his physical presence or a detailed statement by him. This is a temporal and informational leap. What had previously been only a foreshadowed financial danger begins to acquire the status of a reported present circumstance. It would nevertheless be wrong to invent the completion of his fate, a death, or a rescue. The point is precisely that an element of the old premonition is being realised within the story's economic setting while the rest remains undetermined. A narratological reading distinguishes the partial fulfilment of an earlier sign from the final unfolding of the character's entire life.

The Limits of Knowledge About the Financial Network

Satyavrat's documents contain multiple links among dates, accounts and transfers. Following disclosure, the network's shape becomes clearer. Yet greater clarity does not mean that every investigative stage has been completed or every detail of the organisation established. Nand himself expresses doubt that such an extensive truth can ever be known in full. His question limits the apparently confident narrator's account of revelation. Readers thus encounter a complex world of partial discoveries, not the illusion of an instantly complete final report. The chapter's central difference is between a previously secret pattern becoming publicly recognisable and the much larger claim that all consequences, actors and financial relationships have been conclusively determined.

Hope and Grief at the Same Time

The emergence of evidence produces hope and mourning together in the village. Hope arises because previously obscure connections are becoming publicly discussable. Grief returns because the names of lost relatives and the memory of long-unresolved harms become newly vivid. The narrative therefore resists turning exposure into a simple victory celebration. Knowledge of causes cannot restore bodily presence or remove bereavement. The coexistence of these emotions is an important restraint in the community's story: a political and informational advance can be real while its human cost remains irreparable. The chapter gives both feelings space instead of declaring that newly visible responsibility has already supplied the consolation of complete justice.

Burhbā's Image: Truth Is a Lamp, Not the Sun

Burhbā tells Nand that truth is not the sun but a lamp. The image abandons the fantasy of a universal illumination that instantly ends all darkness. A lamp makes it possible to see a limited distance and take the next step. Each date, account and recovered name can be imagined as a separate source of light, and their accumulation can reduce obscurity. This recurring image from the novel's earlier chapters now serves the narrative organisation of investigation. It is Burhbā's experiential metaphor, not an invitation for the critic to impose an independent philosophical system of verification. Its force resides in the measured relationship between a particular discovery and the wider truth still outside the visible circle.

The Folk Song's Dawn and the Prose's Uncertain Day

The folk song announces dawn, whereas the prose clearly indicates that the struggle has not ended. The difference in illumination defines the chapter's tone. The publication of evidence is a step towards daybreak, not the completed day itself. The song gathers communal confidence and hope into an image of renewal; the prose retains the duration of unresolved institutional conflict. Their differing tempos keep the reader alert to both progress and risk. Material has indeed emerged from concealment, and that achievement should not be diminished. But neither the entire network nor every consequence of its operation vanishes when the facts first reach the public. The chapter remains situated between the first light and a future still uncertain.

Hidden Names Enter the Newspaper

Names once spoken only in anxious whispers around homes now appear in print. The change of medium alters their social location: a private fear becomes a subject of public discussion. Yet journalism itself involves selection, arrangement and the language of a new narrator. Chapter [–57]

showed how an outsider's book could misrepresent the village; that memory makes the safeguarding of voices in a new public account a relevant question. The present prose identifies the journalist as trustworthy, but does not reproduce the complete news article. Criticism can acknowledge the expansion of visibility while remaining attentive to the fact that the published text constitutes another version of events, not an unmediated transfer of every speaker's words.

The Limits of a Family's "Slight Peace"

Some families, having learned names and possible causes associated with their grief, experience a "slight peace". The adjective matters. The narrative offers a measure of relief, not comprehensive restoration. Knowledge can alter the way loss is borne without making the lost relative return. At this point the public story of access to information touches the intimate emotional lives of those affected. The chapter does not identify every family or describe each person's response separately. It would therefore be inaccurate to claim an identical consolation for all. The limited peace is a carefully qualified achievement, and it reinforces the central difference between recognition of suffering and compensation for its consequences.

Public Disclosure and Judicial Determination

The chapter establishes the circulation of the suspected network's story through public channels. It does not stage a final court verdict, punishment, forfeiture of assets or comprehensive repayment of losses. "The Evidence Comes to Light" promises an opening, not a judicial conclusion. Maintaining this distinction leaves necessary room for the events that follow. If journalism were treated as the completion of legal justice, both the novel's remaining chronology and the continuing uncertainties of affected people would become unintelligible. The episode's real institutional significance lies in moving information out of private notebooks and making further scrutiny possible. Visibility and accountability are related processes, but they have not yet been shown to coincide entirely.

Retrospective Rearrangement of Earlier Narrative Threads

Readers already know of Chandrapal's imperfectly understood participation in transfers, Batuknath's moral decline, Satyavrat's quiet observations and the recurring overseas name. The present chapter brings these strands into a new sequence. This retrospective arrangement changes the apparent meaning of earlier chapters: separate biographies and troubling hints begin to look like possible components of a common system. The narrator's suggestion of an emerging "complete picture"

should nevertheless be understood partly as an expansion of perspective. It does not mean that the full evidentiary history has become accessible on the page. The chapter demonstrates how a long novel can make previous episodes acquire fresh connections without retroactively eliminating the specific uncertainties with which each was first narrated.

Nand's Work in Circulating the Documents

Nand undertakes to make the newly available material known to people throughout the village. His responsibility has expanded beyond the original search for one anonymous worker. He is not represented as the owner of a newspaper or the judge in a courtroom; his practical agency lies in communication and the linking of public information to communal memory. Through this action, the novel develops its prospective successor into an active witness. Burhbā's image of individual lamps gains a social correlate in the patient distribution of particular pieces of evidence. The action is modest compared with dismantling an international network, but it is definite and meaningful within the limits of what Nand can presently do.

An Incomplete Victory in the Closing Sentence

The closing prose says that the darkness begins to retreat for the first time. The verb “begins” is crucial. It marks the start of a development rather than the finished removal of danger. The first public shift against the concealed system has occurred, but the longer struggle remains incomplete. The image of emerging light offers relief without denying the risks of the subsequent stages. This qualified victory fits the novel's wider history, where major struggles for justice have often achieved partial results that later generations must extend. A critic should preserve the imperfect tense of change rather than turn an opening movement into the absolute destruction of the network.

Overall Assessment: The Expansion of a Silent Witness's Voice

“The Evidence Comes to Light” marks a major threshold between private accumulation and public narration. Satyavrat's notebook, Gop Kumar's assistance, journalism, an investigative agency, the renewed alignment of debtor, lawyer, account holder and overseas connection, the families' grief and Burhbā's lamp image together create a layered account of disclosure. Its achievement is to state both hope and limitation. Certain hidden connections are becoming accessible; their entire social and legal consequences are not yet resolved. The folk song's dawn and the prose's incomplete light must remain distinct. What was once the labour of a quiet observer has become a publicly shared story capable of further questioning and action.

Critical Section 94 | Original Chapter −7 — The Experience of a Half-Ghost

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From External Investigation to the Inner World of Dream

Chapter [−8] takes Satyavrat's documents into journalism and institutional investigation. In [−7], the exhausted Nand falls asleep against the roots of the peepal. The narrative passes from public disclosures and institutional voices to a private experience shaped by dreaming. Its attention shifts away from the immediate mechanics of exposing the suspected network without abandoning the central concern: Nand is still troubled by the labourer whose name remains unknown. The fatigue and grief produced by his outward search prepare an inward episode of unusual intensity. The chapter is therefore a pause in the forward movement of investigation, but it also deepens the protagonist's relation to memory and the people whose lives his work seeks to preserve.

Resting His Head on the Tree's Roots: Body Meets History

Nand rests his head against the roots of the tree that has long served as a witness to the village. The physical gesture is charged with meaning: a living body in the present touches a place associated with centuries of narrated experience. The roots have already figured in accounts of construction, water protection, communal rituals and remembrance. Falling asleep there gives Nand's grief a particular cultural location. This association, however, does not require the critic to establish the tree as an independently verified supernatural cause of the ensuing vision. The prose provides a clear sequence of exhaustion, sleep and dream. Its symbolic force derives from the convergence of an ordinary bodily condition with a place densely inhabited by historical memory.

The Explicit Threshold into Dream

The prose states plainly that Nand descends into deep sleep and then sees Burhbā's figure “in a dream”. These phrases determine the narrative level of what follows. The earlier accident in the river, the publication of banking information and the dream image must not be treated as three identical kinds of factual event. Dreaming is a real mental experience narrated within the fiction, but the appearance of Burhbā's figure inside it does not prove that a separate body materialised before an awake Nand. A precise analysis retains the frame provided by the narration itself. By doing so it allows the dream to matter imaginatively and emotionally without confusing an inner vision with an externally witnessed encounter.

A Partly Visible Face and an Uncertain Identity

Nand sees an aged figure seated upon a branch. The face is indistinct, although the eyes convey gentleness. This incomplete visibility gives the chapter's "half" an immediate visual form. Recognition is affective rather than a fully detailed identification. The figure conveys peace but offers neither a definite message nor new factual information. Positioned, as it were, between smoke and light, the image produces an impression of presence that remains incomplete. The narrator does not remove that uncertainty by supplying an unequivocal spoken name or explanatory revelation. The dream's value lies in giving shape to consolation under the conditions of bereavement, not in delivering a completed document of identification or a verified supernatural account.

Burhbā's Silent Presence: An Unspoken Message

Within the dream Burhbā says nothing. He merely looks at Nand, as though indicating that he is proceeding along the right path. The phrase "as though" matters because the apparent meaning is interpreted by Nand; it is not an utterance quoted from the figure. He reads the reassurance he needs into the gaze. Were a critic to transform this silence into a specific command, a hidden documentary clue or the name of an offender, the source's restraint would disappear. The narrative power of the silence consists precisely in producing significance while withholding linguistic certainty. It is a form of consolation that allows interpretation but does not settle the facts of the ongoing investigation.

The Grandmother's Story: Giving a Social Name to an Experience

At dawn Nand tells his grandmother what he has seen. She calls the experience that of a "half-ghost", placing an individual dream within the vocabulary of the community. Through her act of naming, Nand's private sensation becomes intelligible in relation to older village memories. Yet her words are a character's cultural explanation, not an independently tested classification of phenomena in the external world. Readers can retain two overlapping possibilities: a dream prompted by grief and an unusual experience imaginatively connected to accumulated memory. The chapter gains artistic complexity by allowing both to remain available. The grandmother does not erase the dream's psychological conditions; she supplies it with an inherited language of significance.

The "Half-Ghost" as a Figure of Living in Two Worlds

The grandmother explains that someone who becomes a witness has one foot in the present and another among names from the past. This bodily image gives the "half-ghost" its symbolic form. "Ghost" here need not mean a frightening apparition. It names an enduring relationship with

times that have passed. Nand cannot have been an eyewitness to events centuries before his birth, yet by hearing and preserving stories he can experience their ethical presence. The comparison therefore helps describe intergenerational remembrance. The witness's identity becomes divided between immediate life and responsibilities inherited from people who can no longer speak. This double belonging is metaphorical and narrative, not a claim that Nand has physically left the present world.

The Relationship Between Grief and Vision

Before falling asleep, Nand has spent the day looking for the worker's name; he is distressed and deeply tired. The text makes this preparation explicit. To treat the dream solely as a supernatural gift would suppress its psychological context. Conversely, reducing it to an automatic effect of exhaustion would disregard the grandmother's interpretation and the symbolic power of the village's long history of memory. The narrator ultimately preserves the uncertainty by asking whether the experience was real or an imagination produced by grief. That unresolved question is an artistic feature, not an error requiring correction. A faithful critical reading maintains the interplay of bodily fatigue, longing, inherited belief and the difficulty of knowing what a dream means.

Retelling Old Stories as an Oral Inheritance

Nand's grandmother recounts the shell-and-silver episode, Hulāsā's water burial and Sukhdev's unnamed death. This selection is not arbitrary. Error of perception, destruction by water and disappearance from remembrance are three major strands that illuminate Nand's immediate predicament. The narrator does not reproduce every earlier chapter in full. Through a selected group of names and family narration, the past becomes active again. Recollection is also an invitation to readers of the long novel to revisit what they have already encountered. Ancient conflicts enter the contemporary protagonist's world through another person's voice. Oral transmission makes historical memory a living relation rather than a list of completed episodes.

Three Locations of the Voice: Air, Leaves and Within

After the dream, Nand experiences Burhbā's voice in the wind, in the rustling leaves and in his own capacity to distinguish right from wrong. This sequence moves from outward natural sound towards inward ethical discrimination. No single physical source of the voice is established by the narrator. The effect belongs to the novel's magical-realist handling of remembrance: everyday noises and exceptional associations can be experienced together without a definitive boundary. Yet the prose does not finally adjudicate their literal status. The voice is meaningful because it

passes through several forms of apprehension. What was earlier spoken aloud by an elder can persist as an ethical resonance within the younger witness, even while the source of particular sounds remains open.

The Folk Song's "Complete Name" and the Prose's Limited Result

The folk song suggests that knowledge of a complete name diminishes the fear of the half-ghost. The prose does not show that Nand has now identified every dead person or entirely overcome his fear. Instead, it describes renewed calm, courage and attachment to earlier stories. The song expresses a communal ideal of full recognition; the experience in prose is a partial consolation made possible through memory. Treating the lyrical declaration as the success of the actual investigation would remove the unresolved question on which Nand's work depends. The chapter gives him strength to continue searching, not the names and documentary proof that would end the search.

Dream Time: Twelve Centuries Within One Night

Nand sleeps for a single night, but his grandmother's stories allow him to feel nearly twelve centuries intertwined with his own few years. This concentration of time is a principal narratological device of the chapter. Generations that occupied extensive historical periods are brought into the inward experience of one character. The time of memory differs from that of a chronological ledger. Calling this a disorderly sequence would miss the purposeful combination of two temporal forms. The physical night is brief, while the remembered events it holds extend across the novel's enormous historical scope. The dream permits the past to be encountered as an emotionally simultaneous presence without erasing its chronological distance.

Burhbā's Voice and Nand's Moral Judgment

Towards the end, Burhbā's voice sometimes becomes the inward voice through which Nand judges right and wrong. The elder's speech has moved from an external dialogue into a possible ethical criterion within the protagonist. Nand need not wait passively for an uninterrupted series of commands from Burhbā. Instead, he can relate remembered teaching to the decisions that arise in his own circumstances. In this sense, the half-ghost experience need not diminish his autonomy; it participates in the formation of a witness capable of acting. Yet an inward voice is not represented as a guaranteed solution to every practical danger. The text indicates moral orientation and persistence, not perfect knowledge of future actions.

The Possibility of a Literal Ghost and Narrative Restraint

The grandmother says explicitly that Burhbā is not a frightening ghost, but the village's surviving memory. Her explanation provides an interpretive grammar drawn from communal belief. Nonetheless, the term "half-ghost" retains an opening for an experience that seems unusually vivid or difficult to classify. Neither declaring the apparition a demonstrated supernatural being nor dismissing the episode as mere ridiculous superstition is required by the source. Its strength rests in an unresolved threshold, where a bereaved person experiences communication with lives belonging to other times. The critic's task is to explain how the narrative sustains this threshold while respecting the explicit dream frame and the grandmother's cultural interpretation.

Why the Dream Does Not End the Search for the Labourer

Nand dreams, talks with his grandmother and remembers old stories. He does not thereby discover the worker's real name, obtain the contractor's authentic accounts or complete the map of the suspected financial network. The dream therefore does not replace investigation. It lends personal meaning and renewed endurance to a search still requiring evidence. This restraint saves the novel from resolving a social and documentary problem through an easy supernatural answer. The identity of the witness is deepened internally, but its value must still be tested in public action. The unknown labourer remains unknown, which preserves both the practical necessity of further inquiry and the ethical obligation that first moved Nand.

Overall Assessment: The Importance of an Undecided Vision

"The Experience of a Half-Ghost" makes uncertainty the centre of its form. Nand's grieving body, the peepal roots, the explicit entrance into sleep, an indistinct figure, his grandmother's name for the experience and the continuing inner voice produce a liminal episode rather than a final revelation. Its result is a more intimate relationship between Nand and the village's past. The question of whether the vision was literally true or imagined through grief remains unanswered. Retaining that unanswered question allows the chapter to function as a transition in magical realism and memory-based narration, where the emotional reality of remembrance does not depend upon a conclusive supernatural explanation.

Critical Section 95 | Original Chapter −6 — Gop Kumar's Final Page

The prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From an Unfinished Compilation to the "Final Page"

In Chapter [−30], Gop Kumar was bringing inherited materials together; in [−13], their compilation was approaching completion. Here, in [−6], he writes the final name upon his final page. The progression matters because archival labour has become a lifelong undertaking, not a single administrative task. This chapter presents an actual scene of handing over the accumulated work and must therefore be distinguished from the earlier chapters' anticipations of completion. Yet Gop Kumar completes what has been collected up to the present. The future event for which Nand and Ananya are being prepared has not yet been written. The final page belongs to one collector's achievement and lifespan rather than to the absolute end of every story the village may subsequently have to tell.

The Exhausted Body and the Completed Work

Gop Kumar is extremely old; his hands tremble and his eyesight has faded, while his purpose remains firm. The disparity between bodily decline and continued commitment gives the chapter its principal sensory and emotional pattern. The narrator does not invent an immortal author. Instead, the mortality of the person who writes is set beside the aspiration to preserve work beyond an individual lifetime. The archive matters because someone with finite time constructs an arrangement through which names and experiences may remain available after death. Physical frailty thus prepares the ethical significance of the later handover. Its pathos comes not from supernatural escape from mortality, but from the effort of a human life spent carrying other lives forward.

Joining Pages Across Different Media and Ages

Materials extending from the age of Vācaspati through Yadavānand's secret register, Haripati's manuscripts, Gangadhar's printing press and contemporary digital records enter the same compilation. Their different forms are central to the intellectual drama of the work. Leaves, paper, printed pages and marks retained on screens all have preserved narratives under different historical conditions. Gop Kumar constructs connections among them rather than declaring one medium the sole valid repository. The source does not reproduce every manuscript or give a complete inventory of editorial decisions. Its assertion of comprehensiveness is therefore a meaningful narrative claim, not a technically verified

catalogue. The episode celebrates a many-sided inheritance of writing while leaving the detailed work of comparing all versions largely unstaged.

Victims and Powerful Figures Together in the List

The compilation brings together the shell-and-silver error, Hulāsā's water burial, Sukhdev's unnamed death and the newer records. This is not a triumphal procession limited to celebrated heroes. Misperception, humiliation, death and resistance to oblivion belong to the shared sequence. Remembering consequently entails preserving difficult and uncomfortable histories, not selecting only consoling achievements. The organisation of these fragments makes the novel reflect upon its own material: whose names must not be abandoned when a community's past is given narrative form? The historian's duty enters the story as a problem of inclusion, loss and the ordering of many unequal experiences. The resulting archive is an ethical undertaking as much as a physical collection.

The Final Page Is Full; the Final Story Remains

Gop Kumar fills his last page, but dialogue again recalls Burhbā's warning that the "final chapter" is still to come. The apparent contradiction can first be understood through the distinction between temporal limits. Gop Kumar finishes the material that has reached him during his life; the event Nand and Ananya may later witness remains in the future. Nevertheless, the chapter's references to the "complete story" require readers to retain the two statements together rather than silently erase their tension. Completeness belongs to one stage of an evolving archive. The future cannot be written as though it had already happened. This reservation gives the final page a poignancy distinct from the absolute closure of the book's historical world.

Oral Succession Beneath the Peepal Tree

Gop Kumar summons Nand and Ananya beneath the peepal tree and hands them his compilation. A traditional locus of communal remembrance becomes the setting for the transfer of documentary inheritance. The tangible object is a weighty collection of records, yet the conversation concerns responsibility as much as possession. Written history passes into the hands of prospective witnesses as a future obligation. The scene offers a generational answer to one of the novel's enduring questions: who will write the story when previous narrators can no longer do so? The handover connects oral acknowledgement, physical documents and shared commitment. It does not establish that all subsequent writing is already done, but that there are now people entrusted with continuing it.

"Perhaps You Will Write That Chapter": Uncertain Authorship

Gop Kumar tells Nand and Ananya that perhaps they will write the missing chapter. The word "perhaps" is an essential marker of narrative uncertainty. Their possible authorship is offered as an open responsibility, not the inevitable fulfilment of an already completed destiny. The handover can therefore be both a blessing in the present and a question about autonomous action in the future. It does not imply that the coming events have been written in advance or that the final book has already been produced. The unwritten page remains a site of expectation for the reader. The characters are given the means of bearing witness, but the actual work of witnessing the next event still lies beyond this scene.

Burhbā's Praise and the Memory of the Archivist

Burhbā honours Gop Kumar for his patience over a lifetime. This acknowledgement gives the scene a second significance. The person who has preserved the names of others must also become an object of remembrance. The authority of the compilation is no reason to make its maker invisible. A sequence running through Yadavānand, Vibhā and Gop Kumar becomes a history of those who kept records as well as those whose lives the records contain. The novel thus acquires a reflexive awareness of authorship and historical labour. Writing the history of the forgotten also requires recognition of the work by which their names were carried into another generation's understanding.

Two Obligations: The Material and the Responsibility

Nand and Ananya hold the compilation and remain silent for a long time. This silence is not merely an expression of respectful emotion; it makes visible the burden they have received. The collection contains names, songs, injustices and accounts of resistance. Preserving it is one obligation; becoming witnesses to the next event is another. Burhbā offers the ethical direction of the task, while Gop Kumar provides its tangible materials. Their contributions are distinct and complementary. This dual arrangement prevents memory from becoming an entirely abstract exhortation. The new inheritors physically hold the evidence gathered by earlier generations and must decide how its meanings will be protected and continued.

Gop Kumar's Death: The End of a Long Labour

Gop Kumar dies peacefully a few months after the handover. The interval is important: transferring the compilation and dying are not simultaneous events. The character completes his immediate life's work and then reaches the limits of his time. The novel does not stage a spectacular accident, intervention by a magical jewel or new event connected with the body. His

ordinary and quiet death focuses attention upon the years of patience and the records he has saved. The accomplishment is neither immortality nor physical return, but the deliberate preparation of successors before he is gone. The death therefore closes one life while allowing the activity to which it was devoted to continue.

The Rustle in Channa Grove: A Plural Voice of Farewell

It is said that on the night of his death a faint rustling arises from Channa Grove's roots. The reporting phrase "it is said" places the account within the voice of communal recollection or hearsay. The narrator does not use the detail to establish a scientific claim about conscious trees. The rustling recalls the grove's earlier trembling, but its emotional significance has altered. The former movement accompanied fear and warning; the present sound suggests respect and farewell. One natural setting acquires different tonal roles in the progress of a long story. Its apparent response belongs to the novel's poetic relation between place, memory and human departure without becoming a verified independent cause of death or an unambiguous supernatural message.

"The Witness Changed, but the Story Did Not Break"

The folk song declares that the witness has changed while the story remains unbroken. The line is more than consolation after a death; it states a principle of the multi-generational narrative. The preceding songs, registers, oral accounts and digital documents can be regarded as different means of sustaining continuity. Yet that continuity remains dependent on Nand and Ananya's future work. The song expresses an ideal rather than furnishing proof that the collection will never be damaged, misunderstood or abandoned. The prose supplies a physical basis for the hope by showing the documents handed over and responsibilities accepted. The survival of the story is therefore neither automatic nor a simple denial of loss: it is a duty that living inheritors must practise.

Ananya and Nand: A New Test of Collaboration

In [–18], Nand and Ananya began a joint digital heritage project. Here Gop Kumar formally hands the compilation to both of them. A collaboration in its early stages thus acquires publicly acknowledged responsibility. The event is not an explicit declaration of romance, marriage or the settled course of their shared lives. It concerns the reception of pages and a commitment to their continued use. The novel prepares a field of joint work by bringing together questioning, technical skill and the historical archive. Their relationship advances through common duties rather than through an already narrated private resolution. The responsibility now accepted will have to be measured against what they subsequently do.

The Compilation as an Internal Reflection of the Novel

Gop Kumar binds scattered histories from many centuries into one collection; the novel itself gathers far-flung lives and events into a single narrative form. The resemblance makes the compilation a story within the story, reflecting the act of authorship that produces the larger work. Nevertheless, Gop Kumar's paper and digital compilation is not thereby literally proven to be the entire novel read by the audience. The relation is structural and imaginative rather than a claim of physical identity. Once this distinction is respected, the reflexive design becomes especially suggestive. The narrative represents its own concerns with selection, sequence, preservation and the authority to tell the past through the work of a character who has spent his life assembling records.

The Interval Between Death and Inheritance

The prose gives an ordered series of stages: the last page, the handover, an interval of several months, and death. The succession is not an improvised response forced upon the new witnesses by sudden grief. Gop Kumar has the chance to place his materials in other hands while still living. This temporal arrangement joins the foresight of older ritual practices to an organised modern concern for preserving documents. The person acknowledges mortality without abandoning the task of arranging the future care of what he has written. The narrative meaning lies precisely in the distance between completion of a stage of labour and the biological end of its maker. Responsibility can be transferred deliberately rather than discovered only after loss.

Protecting Lost Names and the Names of Their Protectors

Throughout the centuries of the crocodile stories, registrars and witnesses have tried to save the names of people otherwise forgotten. Gop Kumar himself now joins the dead. His name survives in Burhbā's speech, in the pages of his own compilation and in the commitment of Nand and Ananya. The novel therefore extends its double obligation: preserve the memory of the injured, and preserve the history of those who worked to remember them. The two forms of care are related without being identical. The survival of a name is an emotional and cultural continuation, not the bodily return of a person. This poignant difference remains central to the ethics of a narrative committed to remembering those whom time has taken away.

Overall Assessment: From the Final Page to a New Page

"Gop Kumar's Final Page" is an important resting point in a cumulative narrative, not its absolute conclusion. The trembling hands of an aged collector, documents from different centuries, the scene of transmission

beneath the peepal, the silence of Nand and Ananya, Gop Kumar's death some months later and the grove's reported farewell create a moving representation of historical labour. His collection is complete up to the present, while the anticipated final event remains unwritten: this distinction is the chapter's decisive textual limit. Its achievement is to define the act of writing as more than gathering paper. Witnessing becomes a responsibility passed from one living person to another, even as the former witness's own life comes to an end.

Critical Section 96 | Original Chapter −5 — The Exposure of the Network

The prehistory · Narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Title's Promise of Disclosure and the Prose's Limited Achievement

The title The Exposure of the Network brings readers to what appears to be the long-awaited revelation. Yet the opening prose qualifies its scope with the words “at least locally.” This qualification governs the chapter's narrative structure. Readers may expect every connection in the network to be uncovered, whereas the narrated developments extend only to the first stages of publicly identifying local participants and taking action. The crucial tension lies in the growth of collective awareness from incomplete information. Interpreting the title as a declaration of total victory would erase precisely that tension. The title sets the horizon of expectation; the prose marks how far the investigation has actually advanced.

Months of Investigation: The Compression of Extended Action

The phrase “after months of investigation” condenses a long process into a brief temporal indication. The reader is not shown every interview, inspection of documents or successive investigative day. Instead, the account presents the social consequences of evidence accumulated through previous chapters. This economy gives priority to the public implications of the discovery rather than a procedural chronology. It also leaves significant particulars outside the scene: individual charges, the precise amount of money defrauded, and particular judicial orders. Such absences cannot legitimately be supplied by the critic as if they were narrated facts. The narrator compresses elapsed investigative time while concentrating its moral implications.

The Separate Threads of the Two Investigators Converge

In Chapter [−9], Nand pursues the identity of the unrecorded worker while Satyavrat traces the movement of money. Chapter [−5] brings those two inquiries into a shared picture of local fraud. This is more than the meeting of two characters; it is a convergence of different documentary methods. Nand's diary resists the reduction of human beings to numbers, whereas Satyavrat's banking notebook preserves otherwise invisible connections between financial transactions. Read together, the records place individual suffering beside institutional circulation. The narrative's partial solution consequently arises neither from an isolated feat nor from

miraculous knowledge, but from the linking of parallel lines of patient investigation.

Batuknath's Journey: From Social Hope to the Dock

Batuknath first appeared as a promising legal student committed to defending the poor. Chapters [−33] and [−16] progressively disclosed the erosion of that hope. Here he stands before the court as an accused person. The courtroom acquires a pointed irony: the legal institution whose procedural delays he once exploited to the disadvantage of others now requires him to answer allegations. Yet entry into legal proceedings is not synonymous with conviction. The narrative culmination of an ethically compromised career is visible, but the judicial process remains open. Reading the appearance in court as an already completed sentence would replace the chapter's actual temporal sequence with an invented result.

The Elders' Perspective: Grief Rather Than Satisfaction in Punishment

The older villagers who witness Batuknath in court remember more than the accused lawyer's present circumstances. They also recall a bright and apparently honest boy. The prose specifically privileges their grief over a defeated hope above straightforward satisfaction that justice may be done. Two times of one life occupy the same scene: early communal expectation and later disgrace. This retrospective presence complicates any response limited to celebration of punishment or alignment with a prosecution. The ethical loss includes the disappointment of a village, a school and those who once trusted the child's promise. Remembering the earlier good does not negate the necessity of judging the later conduct.

Chandrapal: Participation in the Network and the Problem of Ignorance

Chandrapal's mule account provides another important strand in the local exposure. The text indicates that, even after evidence of his ignorance emerges, he must undergo a difficult investigation. His position is therefore deliberately double. Burdened by debt, he did not fully understand the account's use; nevertheless, money moved through it. The critic cannot transform him into either an entirely innocent bystander or the proven organiser of the scheme. His situation lies at the intersection of incomplete knowledge, temptation, responsibility and a larger institutional network. The existence of an investigation is not a judicial penalty, and his lack of comprehension does not make the transactions disappear.

The Fisherman of the Folk Song and the Incomplete Catch of the Prose

The folk song imagines an exposed net in which the fisherman, rather than the fish, is finally caught. It is a memorable image of popular justice: the controller of the trap becomes its captive. The prose, however, leaves Lau Kin-Hung beyond the reach of the local proceedings. The song's comprehensive "fisherman" cannot simply be equated with the individuals presently answerable in the locality. Its rhythm voices the moral ambition of a prolonged struggle; the narrative specifies the limits of that struggle's current success. These levels have different temporal perspectives. Their coexistence should be examined rather than dissolved into an unqualified announcement of triumph.

The Glass Tower as an Unseen Centre

Even as locally implicated characters become visible, the distant glass tower remains a centre the narrative does not directly enter. This absent presence is characteristic of the network plot. Readers hear a name and receive indications of remote direction, but they witness neither a decisive arrest abroad nor a final confrontation with that centre. News reports, banking records and characters' inferences mediate its existence. Fear radiates from what remains out of sight. Rather than expose the remote operator in a dramatic scene, the narrative displays the distributed effects of that power within village life. The unseen centre thereby continues to organise anticipation.

The Return of Yashpati and Memory Across Narrative Divisions

Burhbā recalls the unresolved ending of Yashpati's story. This reference connects an earlier historical episode with the present digital network through a particular moral analogy. Centuries and forms of oppression differ, but incomplete justice repeatedly transfers responsibility to later generations. The comparison is not the crude assertion that history mechanically repeats itself. Burhbā's memory establishes a functional resemblance between separate crises. Yashpati's circumstances must not be mistaken for those of Lau Kin-Hung's modern financial network. Their significance arises from comparable experiences of unfinished accountability, not from identical historical causes or actors.

The Meaning of an Incomplete Victory Instead of Satisfaction

Nand eventually recognises the achievement not as a defeat but as "a step." This small shift in his understanding matters. At first the remote suspect's continued freedom makes the local success feel painfully inadequate. Burhbā's response enables Nand to connect partial achievement with

continuing responsibility. The narrative does not build his confidence upon the fiction of total victory. Preserving evidence, names and the diary for later struggle becomes meaningful action in itself. Justice is presented as work that can pass to successors, not necessarily as a closed case within a single generation. Nand's renewed purpose does not conceal the unresolved elements.

Collecting Evidence Again: The Archive After Disclosure

A reader might assume that documents become redundant as soon as wrongdoing has been exposed. Nand instead keeps the evidence and diary safe. Their function has changed. Earlier they made investigation possible; now they preserve the record of an unfinished process and provide a basis for future examination. Pages are not merely repositories of completed events. They also hold obligations that may still have to be met. This repeated act of preservation gives the chapter an ending oriented towards further scrutiny rather than closure. The archive remains important precisely because the present disclosure has not exhausted the demands of justice.

Unequal Distribution of Knowledge Among the Characters

Nand participates directly in the local inquiry; Chandrapal does not fully grasp the use made of his account; village elders view Batuknath in court through memories of his childhood; and Burhbā brings centuries of comparative recollection. These characters do not possess identical information. The narrative places divergent perspectives together to construct the meaning of the network. Readers must connect sources as the investigators themselves have done. No single utterance, even Burhbā's, supplies an exhaustive verdict on the entire situation. This distribution of knowledge accords with the partially exposed nature of the network and prevents the complex plot from becoming a single-voiced explanation.

The Crocodile Metaphor: From Body to Economy

Images of the river crocodile, the erasure of names and digital deception converge once more. The crocodile here is not a literal animal in the river but a shape through which readers can imagine a widely dispersed system of exploitation. Burhbā's insistence on names resists the abstraction of injury into financial figures alone. The economic network is thus linked to damaged relationships, broken aspirations and uncertainty within the village. The image has considerable continuity across the long narrative. Yet its figurative scope must not absorb the practical limits of the actual local proceedings; economic crime and natural predation remain different kinds of event.

The Trembling Network and a Change in Narrative Movement

The final sentence says the network has not been broken altogether, but has begun to tremble for the first time. This motion echoes the earlier trembling of Channa Grove while producing the opposite implication. In the grove, trembling warned of approaching trouble; in the network, it marks the first weakening of a concealed structure. A repeated dynamic image can therefore express contrasting narrative states. The echo condenses the sequence's development: fear was justified, the inquiry has achieved something, but a substantial area of danger remains. The final metaphor does not transform that limited weakening into the network's complete destruction.

Overall Assessment: Public Disclosure, Limited but Decisive

The chapter's achievement is not a final judgment on worldwide financial fraud. It is the public recognition of connected local strands, the positioning of Batuknath's long moral history within a courtroom scene, the retention of Chandrapal's ambiguous participation, and Nand's revised understanding of partial success. The opening folk song celebrates a decisive revelation, while the prose protects its historical limits through "at least." That qualification is not a failure of narrative purpose. It prevents the episode from becoming a simple victory song and gives the novel's continuing concern with justice, records and inherited responsibility a more exacting form.

Critical Section 97 | Original Chapter −4 — The Final List of Names

The prehistory · Narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

“Final” in the Title: A Local Completion of Name-Collection

The title promises a final page of enumeration. After months of searching, Nand is said to have recovered actual names of workers who died at the bridge-construction site. Yet this is the list belonging to that local episode, not the ultimate register of every person lost throughout the novel or the world. “Final” closes one small-scale task without extinguishing the long moral obligation to preserve forgotten names. The chapter thus accommodates a particular narrative resolution within an enormous unfinished history. This distinction is essential if the act of completing a register is not to be mistaken for the abolition of the practices that make such registers necessary.

The Search From Village to Village and Family to Family

Nand's labour is not a single spectacular act. Repeated expressions equivalent to “village after village” and “family after family” suggest numerous journeys and conversations, though each encounter is not separately dramatised. Months are compressed into a small narrative compass, while the recurring phrasing preserves the effort's extent. Relationships must be found before the final number can be assembled. The resulting list is therefore more than information extracted from a contractor's register: it also grows from contact with families and their memories. The narrative represents sustained patient inquiry through iterative language rather than a full sequence of scenes.

Crossed-Out Papers and Forgotten Addresses: Two Insufficient Sources

Nand works with the contractor's crossed-out papers and workers' partly forgotten addresses. Neither source is sufficient by itself. An official record may erase a name, while an address may recede from community memory. The chapter refuses to place the whole truth of identity exclusively in an office or in a single person's recollection. Written remains and oral familial connections must be brought into relation before names can reappear. The precise stages of every verification are not presented. The process is conveyed as a condensed pattern of inquiry, not as a fully dramatised investigative procedure. That distinction is part of the original chapter's narrative economy.

"Thirty Names" and "Three Hundred Bodies": A Numerical Problem

A consequential line links "thirty names" with a story of "three hundred bodies." The song repeatedly names thirty, and Nand enters thirty names in his diary. The text does not, however, explain the exact relationship between the two numbers, the status of a possible remaining 270, or why these figures are joined. Criticism must not ignore this discrepancy. Nor may it silently reconstruct the episode as thirty accidents producing three hundred deaths, or as three hundred deaths of which exactly thirty were identified. Either assertion would exceed the prose. The incomplete numerical relation remains an open interpretive problem, and the translation preserves its uncertainty.

The Song's Repetition of Thirty

The recurring phrase "thirty names" becomes a refrain for collective remembrance. The number is no longer only an entry in an account; through song it becomes an audible sign. The song associates each name with a village, resisting the reduction of a list to anonymous totals. Its repetition secures a mnemonic pattern, while the prose's reference to three hundred bodies opens an unresolved background to the count. The two voices are consequently not interchangeable. Their different emphases urge readers to value remembered names without assuming that a memorable refrain resolves every question about the underlying figures.

Name, Village, Family and Story: Four Layers of an Entry

Nand's diary records not only names but also the villages from which people came, their families and their stories. This sequence proposes an ethics of documentation. A name alone can remain a bare sign; a village restores social location, a family restores relationships and a story restores a lived temporal existence. The diary reverses the logic of a labour register that treats workers chiefly as numbers needed for a contractor's administration. Nand seeks the social fullness of persons. Even this achievement does not literally restore the dead to life. It changes how their lives can be remembered and acknowledged rather than undoing physical death.

Triple Loss: Water, Paper and Memory

The narrative says the workers had disappeared in water, from papers and from memory. The three-part formulation separates the physical accident, institutional erasure and social oblivion. The removal of a name from documents compounds bodily loss; the disappearance of family history can compound it further. Nand's work most directly addresses the last two forms of loss. It cannot restore a body to life. The chapter's pathos derives from this exact limitation: preserving a name does not cancel death, but it

can challenge the renewed violence of erasure. A faithful reading maintains all three levels instead of allowing the poetic language of recovery to imply an impossible physical reversal.

Burhbā's Praise and the Initiation of a Witness

Nand asks whether he has become a worthy witness. Burhbā calls him his most worthy descendant. The exchange advances the long story of inherited witnesshood. The younger character returns to the peepal tree to understand the ethical significance of his own work; the elder offers recognition. Yet this affirmation does not grant magical omnipotence. Nand's qualification rests on what he has actually done—searching, writing and reaching families. A promised inheritance becomes credible through action, not through ancestry alone. The recognition is a social and moral initiation, distinct from a supernatural guarantee that every subsequent inquiry will succeed.

The Mother: From Numbers to Particular Grief

The chapter's emotional centre is a mother who has waited for years for her son. Nand shows her the recorded name, and she can weep for the first time. A single small action gives the list sensory and personal meaning. Grief previously suspended by uncertainty gains an occasion for expression and acknowledgement. The narrative does not disclose the entirety of her internal thoughts, nor does it establish that her son's body has been recovered. A page in a diary produces a powerful social effect without becoming a substitute for the missing person. The chapter thereby concentrates the public project of naming into an individual moment of sorrow.

The Mother's Silence and the Limit of Her Voice

The mother's eyes and tears receive close attention, but she is given little direct speech. On one level the silence expresses profound grief; on another the list is compiled and interpreted chiefly through Nand and Burhbā. Her experience is decisive for the chapter while her own words remain comparatively inaccessible. This narrative choice matters especially against the novel's earlier traditions of women's night assemblies and female oral testimony. The tears should not automatically be treated as a complete substitute for her voice. Recognising this limitation evaluates the distribution of speech without inventing statements the mother does not make.

The Return of “The Crocodile Devours Bodies, Not Names”

Burhbā's longstanding aphorism returns at the moment of Nand's accomplishment. This time it is attached to actual work: a written list and

visits to affected families. What had often functioned as a communal declaration of resistance becomes an observable documentary practice. Nevertheless, the moral hope that names will survive is not identical with a guarantee that any given archive will remain accessible forever. The novel draws them together poetically. Criticism can appreciate the added concrete force of the old saying while distinguishing ethical aspiration from the archive's future material security.

From Nand's Private Diary to a Communal Inheritance

Nand began his diary in Chapter [−20]; the accident in [−10] made its work urgent; the thirty entries now give it a more defined shape. The diary has not emerged fully formed as a magical book. It is the product of successive acts of writing. Nand regards each page as a witness's page. That self-description emerges from labour performed over time rather than from an initial label alone. Whatever happens to the diary later, its social value has become visible in this chapter through the recognised names and their effect on a family.

The Claim to a Total and the Difference Between List and Printed Narrative

Although the narrator reports the list as complete, the printed narrative does not furnish the thirty entries one by one. The list exists within the fictional world, but readers do not receive its complete verbatim text. The internal document and the external narration therefore have distinct degrees of detail. A critic who fabricates the thirty names to fill this gap would cease to provide source-based criticism. The point of the chapter is the labour of preserving names, not the publication of the list in full. The omission remains a representational limit even while the completed local search is acknowledged.

The Material Presence of the List Amid Absent Bodies

Nand sits beneath the peepal holding the diary tightly against his chest. The absence of those who died contrasts with the living witness's bodily contact with a document. Paper bears a symbolic weight associated with the dead, but it does not take their place. This touch transforms an administrative-looking list into an object charged with relationship and grief. Memory has a material support: Gop Kumar's compilation and Nand's diary are both tangible inheritances. The chapter's emotional force arises from their capacity to be held and handed on, even while the human lives to which they refer cannot be physically recovered.

Overall Assessment: Numbers Preserved, Persons Recovered in Memory

The Final List of Names restores relational identities to people earlier reduced to numbers. Months of travel, damaged records, contact with families, the refrain of thirty, a mother's deferred grief and the tangible diary combine into a moving narrative of enumeration. Yet the unexplained relation between "thirty names" and "three hundred bodies," together with the absence of the actual thirty-name text, must remain visible in the analysis. Within those limits, the chapter offers a significant scene of memorial justice. Writing a name does not bring back the dead, but it contests their erasure from the community's account of itself.

Critical Section 98 | Original Chapter −3 — The Completion of Twelve Hundred Years

The prehistory · Narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Promise of Completion and the Question of Ending

The title declares the completion of twelve hundred years, but the prose defines completion in a distinctive way. Burhbā's memory, held in relative solitude for centuries, begins to be shared among many voices. This does not settle every injustice or supply every missing name. Completion refers less to an exhaustive archive than to the transformation of remembrance from an isolated burden into collective responsibility. The difference is fundamental to the long narrative. A temporal circle can be ritually completed even while human suffering and social struggle continue. The chapter closes one symbolic movement without claiming that the entire world of experience has ceased to present unanswered questions.

From the "Nearly" of [−22] to the Completed Circle of [−3]

In Chapter [−22], Gop Kumar estimated that almost twelve hundred years had passed, and Burhbā treated the rounded number as a mnemonic rather than an exact measurement. Chapter [−3] now speaks of the circle as complete. The intervening narrative does not provide a newly verified calculation or a sequence of precise historical dates. The later word "complete" is therefore best understood in relation to an ending's temporal design, a ritual number and a shared sense of historical arrival. It does not annul the caution of the earlier count. A number that first helped organise history has become the festive centre of communal remembrance.

The New-Moon Night: Remembrance Within Darkness

The new moon fixes the scene's time and atmosphere. Darkness does not function solely as an omen of danger. The village now uses it as the setting in which ancestral names can be spoken together. Earlier crises made darkness a condition of fear and enforced silence; here it becomes the background to many voices. A recurring place and time can thus acquire new ethical force. Channa Grove remains recognisable while holding different experiences across historical periods. The scene creates this altered meaning through the interplay of environment and human utterance. The night supplies a space for remembrance without eliminating the history of loss recalled within it.

Kabaddi: The Combined Rhythm of Work, Breath and Speech

The rule of calling out names in a single breath transforms kabaddi from competitive play into a living practice of memory. A short physical breath carries the names of lives separated by centuries. The contrast creates an unusual concentration of narrative time: an immense historical duration inhabits a moment of bodily exertion. Remembrance is no longer confined to books or digital files; it becomes an action people can repeat, perform and share. The game accompanies rather than replaces written preservation. Its vulnerable medium—the breath that must end—is also its strength, for other players may continue the pattern.

Nand's First Turn: From Observer to Participant

Nand, previously identified as a successor to the witness tradition, now enters a round of the game for the first time. This concrete act changes his narrative position. He does not merely listen to names or preserve them in a diary; his body and voice participate in the rite. Before he begins, the village falls silent in anticipation. Yet the moment does not remain an exhibition of a solitary hero. Other people soon contribute their own names, transforming concentrated expectation into communal action. Nand's participation matters because it helps initiate a shared practice rather than monopolising it.

Six Spoken Names and Innumerable Unheard Ones

Nand audibly names Hulāsā, Sukhdev, Ratnā, Gangesh, Gauri and Sāvitri. Elders then add the names of grandmothers, grandfathers and brothers lost abroad. The sequence is carefully arranged. Figures established in the novel's historical episodes are followed by more numerous and often unnamed personal lineages. The prose evokes the assembly of names across centuries, but it does not supply a separate printed enumeration of every participant's ancestors. The magnitude of spoken memory and the limited textual sample must be distinguished. By moving from recognisable figures to ordinary family recollection, the scene enlarges the community's ownership of history.

From a Solitary Voice to a Plural Chorus

At first the village listens quietly to Nand's turn. Gradually other voices join until remembrance becomes a collective sound. This movement dramatises a change in narrative authority. For centuries, Burhbā's extraordinary personal continuity held many lives within a single temporal voice; now the practice is distributed among multiple speakers. The gathering is more than a crowd. It makes the right and responsibility to bear witness shareable. Nand remains important, but the narrative passes beyond the confines of an individual protagonist. The ceremony

shows the collective narration of history as an action taking place before the reader.

Burhbā's "Thousand Breaths": Redistribution of Memory's Weight

Burhbā says that the burden once resting upon a single breath is now shared by a thousand. The phrase provides the chapter's governing image. His exceptional longevity is brought into relation with many ordinary, finite human lives. Memory kept alone becomes exhausting; memory distributed through a community can sustain collective existence. In this formulation inheritance means more than transmitting information: it redistributes ethical labour. "A thousand breaths" is figurative, not a verified census of those attending. The image's power comes from making the social transformation of witnesshood physically imaginable.

The Circular Folk Tune and the Relation Between Beginning and End

The song repeats an idea akin to "what begins also ends." The trajectory from the earliest Shankha–Rajata episode to the present new-moon ceremony takes the form of a great circle. Yet the initial mistake of perception and today's naming rite are not literally the same event. Their relationship lies in the return and transformation of older questions. Circular composition does not claim that history repeats every occurrence word for word. It relocates a recurrent motif within a new moral setting. Read in this manner, repetition produces added significance rather than a motionless cycle.

Changed Feelings in the Trembling Roots and Leaves of Channa Grove

In Chapter [–12], the grove's trembling signalled approaching danger. Here roots and leaves seem to move with the refrain of names. The same natural location now conveys warmth and shared recollection. The narrator makes the trees responsive to communal feeling, but does not require an assertion that the roots have literally become the bodies of the remembered dead. Figurative comparison and the novel's magical atmosphere coexist with a collective human event. The transformed emotional meaning of the grove is narratively significant because it links fear, witness and celebration without pretending that their material circumstances are identical.

Burhbā's "First Time": A New Experience Within Long History

Burhbā says that, for the first time, the burden feels light. Within a life extending across an extraordinary historical span, this small expression marks a decisive psychological change. Floods, famines, struggles for justice and repeated acts of naming have not yielded the complete defeat of

a single ultimate enemy. What matters now is the end of solitary witnesshood. Burhbā redefines the meaning of his role through the participation of others. This emotional achievement helps justify the chapter's place near the close of the prehistory. The rounded historical period culminates in shared responsibility rather than absolute command over the past.

A Turn in the Game and the Turn of Generations

A "turn" belongs both to the sequence of players and to the succession of generations. One person calls names, others listen, and then they add their own voices. The game renders inheritance a recurring practice rather than the administrative transfer of a fixed possession. The breathing of one participant is limited, but the next can continue remembering. Oral remembrance is fragile in ways written archives are not, for its individual breath ends. Yet it can also renew itself through participation. The chapter gives both kinds of memory room to exist, declining to make either the universal replacement for the other.

Ananya's Presence and the Position of a Companion Character

Ananya is present at the new-moon assembly with Nand and the villagers, although his is the scene's dominant speaking voice. This distribution is worth observing after her question-centred teaching in [−21] and their collaborative project in [−18]. Calling her absent would be inaccurate, but her independent direct speech does not organise this particular ceremony. In the following chapter the pledge will give her a more explicit voice. The narrative thus allocates different moments of prominence to the two figures: Nand draws the village into public remembrance; Ananya will speak about the instruments of its future preservation.

The Festival Is Not the End: From Voice to Responsibility

The collective naming produces an emotionally compelling sense of conclusion. Yet the following chapter requires a new generation to promise continued work. The ordering suggests that successful remembrance is insufficient unless it leads to future practice. Nand's turn awakens a shared experience, while the subsequent pledge directs it towards sustained responsibility. Chapter [−3] is therefore a summit within a sequence, not the termination of that sequence. The communal articulation of old suffering becomes a necessary preparation for the work that will follow. Emotion and institution are kept in relationship without being treated as equivalent achievements.

Overall Assessment: Twelve Centuries Gathered Into One Breath

The Completion of Twelve Hundred Years concentrates the long prehistory into a scene of collective memory. New moon, kabaddi, Nand's first turn, multiplying ancestral names, Burhbā's thousand breaths and Channa Grove's responsive atmosphere bring a vast span into a present act. What was previously described as almost twelve hundred years becomes a symbolically completed circle rather than the newly demonstrated accuracy of a historical calendar. Within that qualification, the chapter offers a powerful narrative outcome: solitary testimony is redistributed through a community. The next stage—an explicit pledge of continued stewardship—remains to be undertaken.

Critical Section 99 | Original Chapter −2 — The Next Generation's Pledge

The prehistory · Narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

Continuous Time After Kabaddi: From Emotion to Resolve

The episode begins after the new-moon game in Chapter [−3]. The narrator describes the same night's darkness as thinning, preserving an immediate temporal continuity rather than jumping to an unrelated period. The shared feeling produced by speaking ancestral names becomes the foundation for a public pledge. This adjacent placement gives the relationship between remembrance and future duty an enacted form. A communal ritual has already occurred, and a further action grows from it. The chapter consequently treats the emotional effects of testimony as something that can develop into responsibility instead of allowing the rite to terminate in a self-contained celebration.

The Grammar of the Pledge: From "I" to "We"

Nand begins his direct pledge with "we." The pronoun is more than a grammatical plural: it reorganises who is entitled and obliged to bear witness. Earlier Nand wrote a solitary diary and was identified as Burhbā's inheritor; now he addresses the village's young people as fellow guardians. The duty to preserve names moves beyond a family's legacy into a shared public commitment. This collective statement is actually spoken within the scene, not merely anticipated as a future possibility. At the same time, the utterance of "we" does not mean that every young person has already completed the work promised. The speech creates a new collective subject for future action.

Nand's Pledge: Three Inheritances in a Single Ethical Chain

Nand promises to carry forward Burhbā's stories, Gop Kumar's compilation and each person's name. The three objects unite different forms of memory: a long-lived oral voice, a written and digitally extending archive, and the social identity of individual people. They do not simply duplicate one another. Burhbā's speech gives remembrance a living continuity; Gop Kumar's collection supplies a material accumulation of research; and each name keeps attention upon a particular life. Nand does not claim exclusive ownership of these inheritances. His pledge calls for collective stewardship of what has been received and asks the community to protect the links between its several kinds of record.

Ananya's Independent Voice: From Coconut Leaf to Digital Archive

Ananya promises that every suitable means, from the coconut-leaf school to the digital archive, will be brought into use. Her contribution extends her earlier practice of question-based education towards an operationally plural understanding of preservation. Nand identifies the material to be remembered—stories, compilation, names—while Ananya broadens the possible methods of safeguarding and transmitting it. This difference makes the dialogue cooperative rather than redundant. Yet the fully functioning digital archive is not magically constructed at the moment of her promise. It remains a commitment to work that must take place subsequently. The scene establishes direction and partnership, not a completed technical installation.

The School of the Past and the Code of the Present: Coexisting Times

The prose gathers young people with different abilities: some understand computers and code; others know songs and registers; still others bring legal or accounting knowledge. The list condenses much of the earlier prehistory's institutional experience into one communal picture. Distinct capacities are offered in service of the same pledge. This is not a generic celebration of technological progress. Code, oral song, legal understanding and financial accounts require one another if a complex inheritance is to be protected. The chapter does not assign each expert a particular future project in detail, but it sketches the capacities from which shared work may develop.

"Holding a Name Is Not Deliverance": The Folk Song Corrects Itself

The opening song says that merely holding on to a name is not deliverance; genuine release involves listening. This verse introduces an important self-critique into the prehistory's persistent injunction to preserve names. A list alone cannot stand for the human being or the experience behind it. Listening is an ongoing obligation to hear what a record only partly contains. The song states this relational qualification more explicitly than the chiefly preservation-centred pledge in the prose. Read together, the two modes give the naming practice greater ethical depth. The refrain that once offered an almost sufficient remedy now acknowledges the necessity of attentive reception.

Unequal Individual Voices Within a Collective Assembly

The narrative presents the young people as standing together in a single resolve, but Nand and Ananya receive the principal direct speeches. The emphasis on collective assent gives the ceremony unity and economy; it also limits access to each participant's personal ambition, dissent or assigned role. The participation of "every young person" is a statement

within the prose, not a sequence of distinct oaths printed for each individual. Criticism should recognise both dimensions: the affective power of a united pledge and the relative absence of particular voices within that unity. Collective narrative authority need not be confused with an equally detailed representation of every speaker.

Burhbā's Gentle Radiance: A Symbolic Scene of Acceptance

At the moment of the pledge, Burhbā is associated with a soft, steady radiance in Channa Grove. This image continues the emotional transformations of the setting: trembling apprehension in [−12], communal naming in [−3], and now a sense of acceptance. The prose frames the impression through a comparison, as if Burhbā were speaking through the light. It gives no independent physical explanation of the radiance. Its narrative force belongs to felt experience and the novel's magical-realist atmosphere, not to a technical account of illumination. The environment becomes a responsive symbolic witness to the younger generation's words.

A Public Pledge and the Earlier Secrecy of Remembrance

Yadavānand's shadow-register was written secretly for long periods; women's gatherings under the Emergency often needed whispers. Chapter [−2] converts a comparable commitment to memory into an open declaration before the village. This is a meaningful historical transformation in the narrative: forms of preservation once undertaken under concealment become shared public responsibilities. Still, public speech by itself cannot secure every record indefinitely. Education, careful archiving, repeated practice and institutional protection remain to be tested. The scene therefore represents expanded participation, not the permanent abolition of the risks against which earlier generations worked.

The Collective Echo of "You Will Not Be Alone"

In Chapter [−11], Burhbā assured Nand that he would not face the coming trial alone. The current ceremony gives that intimate consolation a communal echo: neither the elder nor the succeeding generation need remain solitary. A phrase first addressed to one anxious individual becomes a structure of shared fidelity. The repetition is distant enough to mark development rather than simple verbal recurrence. A private assurance has found public form. It illustrates how remembered speech can leave the consciousness of a single protagonist and gain renewed life in the many voices of the village.

Dispersal After the Ceremony: The Practical Form of Unity

At the end, villagers gradually return to their separate homes. This dispersal does not negate the pledge. It suggests that a common commitment must eventually travel into households, occupations and ordinary daily tasks. A village cannot remain indefinitely assembled as a single crowd; the durability of unity depends on shared values continuing through different activities. This small ending gives the public declaration a practical social dimension. Solidarity is not simply a few hours together in the open; it must survive in the separate actions by which people live after the celebration has ended.

Gop Kumar's Compilation and Nand's Diary: Two Inheritances Travel Together

The final scene sends Nand and Ananya forward with Gop Kumar's compilation and The Account of the Splash. The first contains a long, broad history of centuries; the second arises from a particular accident and a modern search for erased workers' names. Keeping them together is structurally significant. In the developing succession, the distant past and a recent injustice inhabit the same responsibility. Future work will need both the large historical inheritance and the more local record of harm. Neither ceremonial remembrance alone nor technical digitisation on its own can adequately represent this conjunction.

From Ritual Towards Institution: A Possibility

Calling out names is a collective rite; the ensuing pledge brings education, digital preservation, law and accounting into its possible continuation. This sequence points from cultural performance towards more regular public organisation. The source does not, however, describe a legally registered new institution, an allocated budget or a detailed distribution of offices. The process remains at an inaugural stage. Hope takes the shape of a communal undertaking rather than an exhaustive administrative plan. A responsible criticism should preserve that distinction while recognising the narrative importance of translating ritual feeling into the first terms of future institutional work.

The Approaching Final Chapter: Mystery Remaining After the Pledge

Burhbā's long-anticipated "final chapter" is invoked again. Although the village has completed its collective naming and made a pledge, the coming ethical examination is not finished. The closing language sends Nand and Ananya along a new, difficult path. This is a characteristic ending that contains another beginning. The reader moves from the relief of a communal success back towards anxiety about how the promise will be

tested. The chapter closes as an event, but its challenge remains active. The value of the pledge must be demonstrated in circumstances the present scene has not yet narrated.

Overall Assessment: The Ethics of Remembering, Listening and Acting

The Next Generation's Pledge is a principal scene of ritual inheritance. The echo of kabaddi, Nand's collective address, Ananya's plural strategy of preservation, young people with complementary skills, Burhbā's gentle radiance and two volumes carried forward connect literary memory with social action. The song's insistence on listening corrects the idea that a list of names alone is enough. Yet a public promise cannot be treated as work already accomplished. The continuation of danger and the prospect of future tragedy remain intact. The chapter's force lies in making active, collective responsibility arise from a community's shared act of remembrance.

Critical Section 100 | Original Chapter −1 — The Final Witness

The final numbered chapter of the prehistory · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

Chapter −1: A Real Final Number, Not an Invented Chapter 0

In the prehistory, Chapter [−1], The Final Witness, is the final numbered chapter. Immediately afterwards, a separately titled dramatic text, Videha Theatre Festival (A Modern Tragedy—First Draft), begins. The source does not insert a stand-alone Chapter 0 between these two pieces. Inventing such a chapter for numerical convenience, or treating the play as if it bore the number zero, would alter the original organisation. This point concerns the boundary of the prehistory; the broader work later includes a separately numbered Chapter 0 in its main sequence. The negative-numbered chronology thus ends at a threshold across which the means of narration, rather than only the events narrated, change.

"Final": The End of Events or the Transfer of Narrative Authority?

The title announces a final witness, and the song evokes a falling curtain. But the prose does not make this the end of all remembrance. Burhbā speaks to Nand about a future writer, and the narrative voice begins to cross the boundary towards the reader and theatrical presentation. "Final" therefore names the ending of one arrangement of storytelling rather than the extinction of the literary world. A long narrative formerly held by a single exceptional historical voice yields space to the reader and to a new dramatic medium. The ending is a transfer of authority and form, not a declaration that no one will ever tell these stories again.

The Restricted Scene of a Private Evening: Burhbā and Nand

The chapter opens on a last evening when Burhbā calls Nand alone beneath the peepal tree. The scene echoes the earlier private blessing. Centuries of experience are gathered within the exchange of only two characters. The surrounding villagers are absent from the immediate dramatic field, although they remain indirectly present in the many names that Burhbā remembers. This narrowing produces narrative density. The threshold between eras is approached through an intimate conversation rather than a public festival. The immense collective past is conveyed through the concentrated experience of a younger listener receiving the elder's final reflections.

The Future Writer: A Story Contemplating Its Own Creation

Burhbā anticipates an unseen writer who may one day compose the whole history. His statement makes the process by which a story becomes a book part of the story's own subject matter. Ordinarily a narrator describes the fictional world; here a central character considers the future authorship of that very description. This metafictional turn asks readers to think about the labour of writing, selecting and preserving a vast inheritance. Burhbā gives neither a definite authorial name nor a publication date. The future writer remains a possibility, not a historically identified figure whose identity can be deduced from the passage.

"I Do Not Know": The Limits of the Witness

Nand asks how Burhbā knows about the future writer. The elder explicitly answers that he does not know; he only senses the possibility. This admission is crucial to the chapter's conception of witnesshood. Even a voice extending over twelve centuries cannot claim certainty about the future from its own intuition. The prose separates extraordinary feeling from verified information. Accordingly, the imagined writer should be read as a moving possibility and as the beginning of a metafictional gesture, not as a testable prediction supported by a chain of evidence. Burhbā's restraint preserves the very openness that the narrative is about to stage.

The Experience of Nearness and the Present Reader

Burhbā suggests that the future writer is so near that he is addressing that presence at this very instant. Within the utterance, a future belonging to the fictional world approaches the reader's act of reading in the present. The boundary of narrative time seems to become porous. Readers are prompted to notice their own position: might the apparent address reach them as well? The text generates this question without requiring that the unnamed writer be equated with a particular identifiable person. The force of the moment comes from an experienced proximity between telling and receiving a story, rather than from a literal solution to an authorial riddle.

From the Peepal's Shade Beyond the Stage: Crossing Narrative Levels

The prose describes Burhbā's voice as coming from beyond the stage; then the Sutradhar, or dramatic narrator, emerges from beside the curtain and looks towards the reader. Spatial language now changes the narrative's form. The peepal tree, previously a place of communal memory, is linked to the setting of theatrical performance. A voice earlier mediated by the prose narrator becomes associated with a visible figure who conducts the presentation. This crossing of levels is a striking moment of metalepsis: the machinery of telling a story becomes perceptible within the story itself.

The passage does not merely change location; it exposes a new mode of narration.

The Consequences of the Sutradhar's Direct Address

For most earlier chapters, Burhbā's words reached readers through conversations among people within the village. At the end of [–ɪ], the Sutradhar turns directly towards the reader. The mediation is altered: Nand remains the listener inside the fiction while the reader is addressed from a represented stage beyond it. The sense of distance contracts, although the fictional and extra-fictional worlds do not become literally identical. The effect of metafiction rests on this symbolic breach. It prepares a further change in the dramatic sequence, in which direct audience address will form part of the theatrical mode rather than remaining an isolated surprise.

The Song's Curtain and the Prose's Newly Opened Stage

The folk song announces the lamp's extinction and the curtain's descent. In the narrative that follows, however, the Sutradhar steps out from behind the curtain, and the separately titled Videha Theatre Festival begins. The song's image of closure therefore moves in a different direction from the reader's actual experience. The falling curtain is a poetic expression of completion; the arrival of a theatrical text opens another means of performance. The passage refuses to become an ordinary sealed ending. When readers expect the final stop, the work moves them across into a different genre.

The Final Refrain: "The Crocodile Devours Bodies, Not Names"

The saying repeated through centuries receives its "final" recurrence in this chapter. Its force changes with the context. Preserving names is no longer only a task undertaken against drowning, famine, digital exploitation or the erasure of labour; it is also entrusted to writing, performance and future readers. The distinction between body and name enters the work's awareness of its literary survival. Yet the statement is an ethical commitment articulated in the village's poetic vocabulary, not an incontestable historical law. Names can also be lost. The refrain matters because it continues to resist that loss and gives the transition in narrative authority a recognisable moral centre.

From Shankha–Rajata to the Digital Archive: Assembling Material for Authorship

The dramatic transition occurs after a cumulative history that includes the Shankha–Rajata episode, Hulāsā's water burial, Gop Kumar's compilation, Nand's diary and the collective naming ceremony. The imagined future

writer makes this material newly visible as the substance from which a composed work might arise. Authorship involves more than inventing events; it involves arranging voices already circulating in different media. At this point, however, the principal prose has not yet supplied the entire dramatic work. The new form begins under its own heading. The accumulation of sources prepares the threshold but does not abolish the distinct identity of what follows.

The Separate Heading *Videha Theatre Festival* and Its Textual Boundary

Following Chapter [−1] appears a distinct unit headed Videha Theatre Festival and subtitled A Modern Tragedy—First Draft. Treating it as merely the last paragraph of [−1], or automatically naming it Chapter 0, would suppress an explicit difference in textual organisation. The new material offers a cast, opening framework and dramatic divisions with different formal rules. Its adjacency to the prehistory establishes continuity, but its dramatic title establishes separation. The present section can analyse that change of medium and its initial signs, while a full independent criticism of the theatrical text requires its own limits of reading and evidence.

The Blackened Book: A Play Writing Itself Within the Archive

At the beginning of the new dramatic unit, a thin, nameless blackened book appears at the bottom of Gop Kumar's collection. Its pages begin to inscribe themselves without ink. This joins a material book with an extraordinary act of writing. Earlier documents arose from human hands, dates, research and remembered names; the self-writing play now unsettles the idea that an identifiable compiler controls every story. Gop Kumar's collection remains the inherited repository, but its innermost book begins to disclose a theatrical narrative beyond the normal labour of archiving. The effect is to reopen the question of authorship as an event within the fictional world.

The Stage Director's Desired Happy Ending and the Diary's Resistance

In the opening of Videha Theatre Festival, the stage director wishes to give the play a happy ending. The Sutradhar responds that the ending is not in the director's hands. The disagreement gives dramatic form to a conflict between the shape an artist might wish to impose and the resistance of difficult events. One figure seeks a preferred result; the other acknowledges that the unfolding tragedy cannot simply be wished away. This is the inaugural tension of the play, not yet a complete philosophical judgment

upon its ending. It demonstrates that the production of a narrative has become a subject of contestation inside the narrative itself.

Bijji's Silent Presence and the Protector's Limited Power

The new play's character introduction includes Bijji, a protective mongoose who remains silent, and anticipates that this time its vigilance may fail. The design challenges a conventional expectation that the guardian must triumph over danger. Against the stage director's desire for a happy ending, Bijji's uneasy silence offers a visible counterpoint. Earlier versions of the crocodile image encouraged the expectation of a creature protecting the vulnerable against the predator; the dramatic setting now places protection itself under strain. The text supplies this as a sign in the play's opening, not as an already fully narrated episode in Chapter [–1].

The Crocodile's New Location: The Predator Wearing a Uniform

The play's opening materials use the term "real crocodile" for the corrupt senior official Rananjay Singh, while a wildcat serves as an outward instrument. The inherited crocodile metaphor moves from water, screens and financial fraud into the corruption of protective institutions. The Sutradhar asks whom Bijji can bite when the crocodile wears a guardian's uniform. The question establishes a tragic possibility: danger may occupy the very structure charged with keeping danger away. This is a distinct dramatic pattern. Without an explicit textual bridge, Rananjay's story must not be treated as another legally established stage in the separate case involving Lau Kin-Hung.

Chorus, Direction and Scene: The Prose's Moral Voice Transformed

The dramatic cast includes a chorus, Sutradhar, stage director, Bijji and others. In the prehistory, songs and Burhbā's reflections often supplied the communal moral voice. In the play, the chorus can embody fear, confusion and the public reactions of townspeople. Bracketed stage directions, half-darkness, a blue line suggesting the river and an empty chair translate narrative images into elements meant to be staged. The reader encounters directions for visual and vocal presentation rather than a continuous prose account. The change makes the apparatus of storytelling more conspicuous and gives concrete form to the self-referential ending of [–1].

From One Play to Other Textual Worlds: The Book's Complexity

After Videha Theatre Festival, the source also presents other distinct philosophical dramatic adaptations. This larger arrangement shows that the close of the prehistory does not merely turn a page to the next ordinarily numbered episode. It opens upon a more heterogeneous textual

environment. The present criticism can examine the play as an entrance threshold while respecting its separate literary identity. Compressing all subsequent dramatic material into Chapter [−1], or regarding every theatrical event as a direct continuation of the prehistory's realist action, would erase the work's formal diversity. The transition is significant precisely because narrative rules change.

Author, Narrator, Sutradhar and Director: Four Distinct Positions

Burhbā senses an unseen future author; the prose narrator reports that perception; the Sutradhar addresses readers from across the curtain; and the stage director seeks a happy conclusion. These positions are related but not identical. The distribution of authorial functions turns the act of making a story into a field of disagreement. The ending cannot be determined solely by a character's hope or a director's order. Nor should the narrative voice automatically be identified with every figure who speaks about writing. The distinction among levels is indispensable to understanding the passage's modern narratological and metafictional importance.

The Declaration of Closure and the Expansion of Drama: A Decisive Contradiction

The song sings a completed ending; Burhbā anticipates an unwritten future; the Sutradhar appears before the reader; and a new dramatic text begins writing itself. Three movements coexist: the song's closed cadence, a character's open horizon, and the reader's entry into another genre. The result is an ending that is structurally unstable but generative. This is more than repetitive formal ornament. The work interrogates its own claim to finality. Once each layer is read on its own terms, the seeming contradiction becomes central to the literary design: closing a prehistory can be the means by which another narrative form begins.

Overall Assessment: From the Final Witness to Self-Conscious Performance

The Final Witness is a threshold in the accumulated prehistory. Its private dialogue, Burhbā's limited foresight, the Sutradhar turning towards the reader, the song's closing curtain and the new theatrical heading together grant the long history of memory a self-referential form. The prehistory contains no intervening Chapter 0 between [−1] and the play; the dramatic first draft has its own identity; and a sensed future writer is not an authorial identification certified by the text. With those limits preserved, the chapter does more than end a twelve-century account. It demonstrates how the account comes back to life in the acts of writing, reading and staging.

Critical Section 101 | Original Chapter 0 — Garh Narikela: A Brief Folk Prologue

The main narrative's Chapter o · Narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Narrative Necessity of Chapter Zero

Placed at zero, the extended folk prologue establishes the village's practices of listening before the main sequence of events begins. Bā urges children to hear the village first. In consequence the narration moves away from the posture of an omniscient supplier of facts and creates a setting of collective attention. The claim that the village itself begins to speak makes a geographical place function as a communal narrator. Readers are prepared to ask whose voice will be heard before asking what has happened. Removing this prologue as dispensable material would weaken the internal relations among later songs, leaves, memories and struggles for justice. Its function lies in establishing the conditions under which the ensuing stories can be told.

From a Single Narrator to a Many-Voiced Narrative

The first singer's opening, a second voice taking up the refrain, a third changing a verse and a fourth adding a new incident disclose the composition's own method of storytelling. Collective creativity is not merely a theme of folklore; it helps organise the novel's voices. A grandmother, a boatman, a woman working in the fields and a child provide differing versions of one incident. Such polyphony encourages readers not to depend entirely upon a single authorised account. A memory can continue to exist through multiple tellings, and variation may signify its vitality rather than corruption. This principle will matter when records and songs later disagree about particular events.

Eventless Abundance or the Construction of a Story World?

The chapter contains extensive description, classification, folk narrative and song. For readers expecting immediate, continuous action, its range may feel slow. Yet its narratological task is to prepare locations and devices that later acquire independent significance: the banks of the pond, river water, Channa Grove, coconut leaves, court adjournments, digital screens and the protection of names. These are the building materials of subsequent events. The explanatory voice can nevertheless interrupt scenes and assume an essayistic character. That interruption is a genuine formal risk. An abundance of cultural information must not automatically be counted as an equal abundance of dramatised incidents. Criticism should

hold the prologue's preparatory reach and its slowing of action in view together.

The Narrative Work of a Living Geography

The Kamala-Balan and Ganges rivers, ponds, pools, wells, low-lying fields, embankments and drains are more than labelled features of a map. They help determine livelihoods, danger, movement and death. Water sustains life but can also carry away homes. This doubleness establishes a basis for both the novel's literal crocodiles and the subsequent expansion of the crocodile into a metaphor. Time, too, is locally geographical. People remember events as before a particular flood or after a particular bank erosion, rather than solely by dates on an official calendar. Geography thus becomes a carrier of narrative temporality, shaping how a community places its experiences within history.

The Body of Labour and the Rhythm of Song

The collective calls of fishers drawing a large net, the bodily rhythm of planting rice, a boatman's breathing and the cadence of a mourning song all join music to work and sorrow. A folk song is not simply entertainment pasted onto an otherwise complete scene. Its metre may organise collective action, while that action can alter the refrain. Such mutual influence gives songs an active role in the structure of the narrated world. Still, egalitarian aspirations voiced in music are not the same as equality in actual arrangements of labour. The critic must continue to examine the distance between workers' own voices and songs composed or performed on their behalf.

Material Media of Memory: Leaf, Stone and Voice

The paradox that an official paper may be cut away while a coconut leaf can grow again sets institutional records beside a renewable form of local memory. Leaves, stone, songs, throats and later digital copies provide different media through which a name may endure. Multiple versions of a name can operate as a defence against erasure rather than a defect in recordkeeping. Yet natural material must not be imagined as indestructible. A felled tree can no longer offer new leaves, and the novel itself repeatedly warns of environmental destruction. That internal tension enriches the imagery. The prologue values the regeneration of memory while exposing the ecological conditions on which some of its symbols depend.

Testing the Claim of Social Inclusion

The narrative says that village culture belongs neither to one caste nor to one household alone. It simultaneously presents hierarchies of domestic

space, restricted access to ponds, caste humiliation, the exclusion of girls from play, violence within marriage and invisible labour. The community is therefore neither an immaculate paradise nor a structure defined by violence alone. An important question concerns who may begin a song and who is permitted only to repeat another's refrain. This is a question about authority inside a many-voiced narrative. The proclaimed possibility of inclusion must be tested by later participation in scenes of conflict and decision, not accepted uncritically because it has been expressed as an ideal.

Women's Voices: From Auspicious Song to Resistance

Songs associated with birth, marriage and departure appear beside songs of suffering within marital households, closed doors and domestic violence. The door is consequently more than architecture: it can signify silence and the absence of safety. Women who understand a song's coded warning resolve not to abandon the person endangered. In this small narrative cycle, interpretation of a song becomes practical assistance. At the same time, collective women's voices can sometimes obscure the specificity of a particular woman's experience. Criticism must ask whether the woman whose suffering becomes audible is able to speak, control her story and make decisions. Hearing distress and giving the distressed person authority are related but not identical achievements.

History Taught Through Games

Kabaddi provides a bodily language for responsibility through crossing boundaries, managing breath and bringing a teammate back. A rule requiring forgotten names to be called during turns turns play into an act of remembrance. It also anticipates the later narrative pattern of ghostly kabaddi. Scenes in which caste and gender divisions are crossed on the playing field point towards a democratic possibility. Yet erasing a line drawn in chalk or earth does not, by itself, eliminate the social divisions represented by that line. The moment offers a meaningful symbol of change rather than proof that society has already been transformed in its entirety.

Folk Belief and the Limits of Magical Realism

The Brahma associated with the peepal, water spirits, speaking trees, names written on leaves and the games of ghosts are not isolated in a separate supernatural compartment. They share the village's ordinary space with labour, flooding, courts and domestic life. The critic's principal task is not simply to decide whether each incident can be established by external natural science, but to ask what unheard pain or communal relationship an image makes perceptible. Yet reducing every belief to metaphor would also dismiss the intimacy of the characters' experience. The narrative

permits overlapping modes of reading. Its magical realism arises partly from that coexistence rather than from a catalogue of miracles.

Advance Signals of Future Narrative Cycles

The prologue mentions digital fraud, Ujjwal's tragedy, the guarding of names, women's privacy, the endless date of court proceedings and environmental protection. Readers consequently encounter clues to later plots before those plots are developed. Such anticipatory density invites rereading: subsequent incidents can return new significance to an earlier phrase. It may also diminish the surprise of events whose results have already been suggested. Narrative curiosity can then shift from what will occur to how it will occur and from whose perspective it will be experienced. The prologue therefore enlarges the network of anticipation while creating a formal obligation for later scenes to justify their early explanations.

Multiple Layers of Time

Seasons, centuries, generations, flood marks and instantaneous mobile messages coexist in the same chapter. This variety does not form an ordinary linear chronology. Social time, environmental time and digital time meet and sometimes clash. A folk refrain may condense centuries of experience into a few words, whereas the trembling voice of an elderly woman may slow the pace of a whole paragraph. Such variation deserves close attention. The mere presence of many temporal references is not identical to the sustained representation of experienced duration. The chapter alternates between expansive cultural cataloguing and moments in which time acquires an individual bodily rhythm.

The Arrangement of Twenty-Four Tale-Songs

The latter portion of the prologue presents a numbered series of twenty-four tale-songs, from a leaf lamp on Dakahi Pond to the guardianship of trees, water and the environment. Each unit pairs an episode with a song. The song can turn an episode's meaning into a public refrain, while the episode gives material grounding to that refrain. The units do not all possess the same dramatic density. In some, a character makes a discernible decision; elsewhere, a social principle or cultural illustration is more prominent. It would therefore require care to call all twenty-four fully developed, self-sufficient short stories. Their shared formal pairing matters more than an unverified uniformity of narrative scale.

Official Absence and a Mother's “Present”

A mother's insistence that a person is present in her memory despite being absent from an official register is among the prologue's sharpest narrative

contrasts. The state document fails to recognise someone whom the maternal voice remembers as a complete individual. This anticipates the later story of the missing construction worker, whose identity will similarly be imperilled by paperwork. Maternal memory becomes an alternative archive, but not necessarily the final source of every factual detail. The productive possibility lies in comparing and sometimes combining the testimony of a voice with the remains of written evidence. The novel's documentary imagination is strongest when these different forms of knowledge are read together.

The Coexistence of Essayistic and Poetic Modes

Chapter 0 moves among cultural exposition, lyrical prose, song and short narrative. Such generic mixture supplies a foundation for the novel's breadth. Its stylistic intensity is not uniform, however. Some explanatory passages reduce the independence of characters and increase overt authorial guidance. Readers who prefer to infer meaning from action and dialogue may find these moments over-explicit. An adequate evaluation should acknowledge both the extraordinary range of cultural material and the cost of explanatory interruption to narrative movement. The chapter's mixed form is neither an unqualified artistic triumph nor evidence that it lies outside the novel's central design.

Chapter Zero's Overall Narratological Position

The opening constructs Garh Narikela not simply as a setting but as a "community of listeners." Names, water, trees, labour, song and justice become linked parts of its practices of remembrance. When the later narrative turns to particular deaths, falsified lists or international structures of exploitation, the principles of listening established here change how readers interpret those events. The accomplishment is therefore more than a generalised portrait of folklore: it creates a communal basis for making meaning from conflicts still to come. Its limitation remains that proclaimed possibilities of justice, equality and protection must be tested through subsequent action. The prologue prepares that test; it does not pre-emptively record its success.

Critical Section 102 | Original Chapter 1 — Kabaddi in Channa Grove

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Double Stage of the Opening

The ghostly kabaddi in Channa Grove and the construction of a vast road bridge over the Ganges unfold as parallel stages of the opening. On one stage, players without physical bodies cross the frontiers of time; on the other, vulnerable labouring bodies fall amid unsafe bridge foundations and river water. The author does not reduce these events to a simple chain of causes. Instead, the sound chhapāk—the splash—creates an acoustic bridge between sites. Readers are alternately spectators of the grove and witnesses at the construction site. Through this double staging, the accident is read not merely as a matter of construction management but as a continuing episode in the collective history of remembering and forgetting.

The Unstable Boundary Between a Game and a Trial

The opening does not immediately settle whether this is a game or a judicial proceeding. Boundaries, opponents, capture and the effort to hold one's breath gradually become questions about names, absence and testimony. The contest between the ghosts' team and an opposing team figuratively associated with official seals constructs a theatrical alternative to legal proceedings. Playfulness collides with grief: kabaddi remains recognisably a game, yet the deaths that enter its field cannot be treated as an occasion for carefree amusement. The uneasy coexistence of incompatible registers gives the scene its tragic irony. The game makes institutional conflict perceptible without becoming a literal substitute for a court of law.

Extraordinary Movement Through Time

Within one turn, a ghost may touch 1885, 1934, 1977 and a mobile tower in 2026 before returning. Such movement does not replace historical sequence with a different factual chronology. It is a narrative technique that places past, present and future in visible relation. Freedom from the body permits the spectral players to traverse time; living workers, by contrast, remain constrained by steel bars, makeshift belts and limited breath. Temporal liberty and bodily danger interpret one another. Readers may encounter an image of a later consequence before learning how it is

socially produced. The dislocated sequence makes history available as a network of relations, not a flat procession of dates.

The Distinct Functions of Burhbā, Hulāsi, Pānidubbi and Loth

Burhbā referees the game and speaks from the extended duration of memory. Hulāsi, though without hands, marks the boundary through her gaze, which becomes functionally equivalent to touch. Pānidubbi carries the smell of the Ganges from the village pond, drawing distant deaths into a local aquatic world. Loth usually watches silently, but cement dust comes from his mouth, bringing modern construction into the spectral assembly. These are differentiated narrative actions, not interchangeable manifestations of a single symbol. Together the figures form a collective mechanism of narration: arbitration, observation, sensory transfer and the embodied trace of labour each contributes something the others cannot supply.

The Detailed Accident of Bisesar Paswan

Bisesar's worn slippers, basket of gravel, ascent along a bridge foundation and slipping foot make the accident materially specific. Its immediacy resists any explanation based solely upon supernatural fate. Nand calls for a safety belt, but whether Bisesar hears him remains uncertain, a small gap that sharpens Nand's helplessness in the face of dangerous conditions. The body enters the water in the narrated scene; the person's name is subsequently erased through reporting. Bodily catastrophe and documentary removal thus form two kinds of violence. The crocodile supplies a dramatic image for their convergence, not an exclusive explanation of how the worker fell.

Chhotu: A Character with an Incomplete Name

A second accident concerns the underage son of a Musahar woman. The register records him as twenty-eight, whereas his mother calls him Chhotu. The contradiction exposes the different authority of an official age and a mother's form of address. In the ghosts' game Chhotu cannot recall his full name; Burhbā accepts the available name provisionally. This offers a striking moment of communal compassion, but it does not solve the problem of formal identification. The proposal to amend the record when his real name is found keeps the inquiry open. The distinction matters: a name of affection can preserve a person's presence without satisfying every documentary requirement for establishing identity.

“Worker Absent”: Violence Performed by Language

Nand's report initially includes inadequate safety, underage labour, bodies and the contractor's responsibility. Red pencil removes these words until

only “worker absent” remains. This is not a harmless administrative abbreviation. The editorial operation eliminates the agent, the cause, the injured person and the question of accountability in stages. Because readers witness the cancellation itself, the violence becomes visible even beyond any later legal finding. The written page turns into a narrative stage on which official language acts. A worker whom the river has already swallowed undergoes a second disappearance in the document. The episode makes erasure a performed action, rather than merely telling us that records are unreliable.

The Manufacture of Edward Broom's Prestige

A foreign company's screens, awards, development photographs and the prospect of an ethics lecture at Harvard form a system of global reputation-making. Deaths on the bridge are described in managerial terms as controlled numbers while the same project is prepared for presentation as an institutional achievement abroad. The point is not to offer a comprehensive independent economic history of international business. It is the contrast between an authorised public image and the material scene Nand has witnessed. The distance between Broom's prospective public rhetoric and the workers' circumstances produces a deliberately sharp ethical irony. Readers are positioned to assess what the prestige image excludes.

Fakira Sahni's Alternative Account

The boatman Fakira suggests that more bodies are being thrown into the water rather than that the crocodile population has simply grown. He understands crocodiles as creatures with a role in the natural environment and questions the tendency to make them bear responsibility for human wrongdoing. His intervention complicates the novel's own recurring metaphor. A crocodile is a biological creature; the administrative exploitation called a “crocodile” belongs to another order of action. The distinction prevents the symbol from absorbing the material reality of labour practices, records and decisions. Fakira's voice also adds a critical perspective from a character whose life depends on reading the river directly.

Hulāsi's Account and the Dispute About Her Death

Hulāsi objects to the assertion that her death was suicide, saying instead that she slipped into a well. She is therefore not only a spectral participant in the protection of names; she speaks in defence of a particular version of her own life. That utterance is neither presented as a complete official inquiry nor corroborated by a full set of administrative records. Its immediate narrative importance is the return of a voice previously

subordinated to a classification of death. The coexistence of competing accounts remains essential. The novel's plurality of voices requires readers to distinguish a victim's testimony, an official description and whatever further evidence might be necessary.

A Sequence of Glimpses into the Future

Images of Ujjwal Jha apparently sinking into a screen, smoke around Batuknath's lawyer's coat, Chandrapal's betting slip and Lau Kin-Hung's glass tower introduce seeds of later plots. They do not yet provide a complete explanation of one criminal event. The privileged view of the future belongs to the narrative's mode of presentation, not to everything living Nand knows. Readers receive more indications than the character, yet the meaning of many connections remains unsettled. This imbalance is the means by which anticipation is created. Foreshadowing here introduces possible lines of danger without granting the critic permission to narrate their eventual outcomes as completed facts.

The Recurrence of Words and Sounds

“Kabaddi,” “water,” “burial,” “splash,” “date” and “name” recur across settings. Each appearance changes the word's function: a bodily fall, a deleted line in a file, the sound of a spectral game and eventually the title of a diary. Repetition is thus more than an acoustic pattern. It is a device for transforming meaning as the narrative passes between times and social locations. A splash heard without an accompanying name becomes a question; after a name is recorded, the same sound can become an act of remembrance. A small vocabulary carries the burden of linking very different orders of experience.

Living Nand's Shadow and a Half-Ghost Condition

Nand remains physically at the construction site while his shadow reaches Channa Grove. The double presence must not be mistaken for an account of his actual death. Magical realism here gives visible form to a living witness's mental and memorial attachment. His body stays among endangered workers; his shadow enters the community's spectral world of grief. The division has an ethical significance: participation in suffering exceeds paperwork, becoming an enduring aspect of the person's identity. Yet bodily presence and spectral participation are not the same event. Their distinction enables the novel to draw upon the fantastic without erasing the physical conditions of the construction site.

Expanding Numbers and Critical Caution

The chapter mentions thirty officially recognised deaths, a claim that there may be at least three hundred, and a spectral vision reaching three

thousand. These figures have different narrative and evidentiary statuses. Thirty belongs to the official list; three hundred appears in Nand's counter-claim; three thousand is part of an extraordinary image on a crocodile's back. None can properly be substituted for the others as a single verified death count. Recognising their differences does not diminish the magnitude of suffering. It clarifies the novel's arrangement of institutional records, disputed testimony and symbolic amplification, each of which has a distinct dramatic and critical purpose.

The Final Torn Gamchha as a Material Trace

After the final accident in darkness, a torn corner of a gamchha remains caught in Nand's hand. The body has not been recovered and the name remains unknown, but an object survives. Its subsequent movement from the bridge towards Ba's threshold connects distant narrative sites. It offers the possibility of testimony without yet establishing the dead person's identity. Ba raises the cloth to her forehead, bringing an industrial catastrophe into the intimate space of domestic mourning. The spatial separation between river and courtyard collapses through this small remnant. The object acquires emotional weight precisely because it cannot restore what has disappeared.

Overall Assessment of the Section

The chapter's principal achievement is the force of its layered staging: endangered labourers, the editing away of names, institutional publicity and ghostly kabaddi occupy one interconnected system of signs. The abundance of foreshadowing occasionally diverts attention from the immediate scene, but Bisesar's slippers, Chhotu's incomplete name and the torn gamchha provide a stubbornly material basis. “The crocodile eats the body, not the name” is not a declaration of final victory here. It is an undertaking to search for names through labour that may be lengthy, difficult and uncertain. The narrative turns tragedy into the beginning of responsibility, not its fulfilment.

Critical Section 103 | Original Chapter 2 — The Village on the Right Bank

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

Direction in Space and the Shifting Viewpoint

"The right bank" is not an unchanging geographical instruction. When the Kamala-Balan changes course, the experienced division between right and left may change, while villagers continue to use inherited directions. The instability makes space something lived and remembered rather than a set of inert cartographic coordinates. The title consequently raises an interpretive question: from whose position is the bank designated as right? The narrator's standpoint, the river's movement and village memory interact in the answer. Readers must continually attend to the location of the speaking consciousness rather than assume that the title provides a permanently fixed point on a map.

From the Gamchha to the Family Chest

Ba takes the torn fragment of cloth and opens an old chest with a brass catch. An apparently insignificant possession of a worker is placed beside palm-leaf records, land papers, sacred-thread objects and inherited memories of humiliation. This act opens a private family archive to a public tragedy of labour. The gamchha does not merely stand for grief: it enables the movement into an extended flashback. As the chest opens, narrative time turns towards Lattar Thakur and Kalit. The transition is materially motivated; the reader enters ancestral history through the handling of an object, not through an unannounced historical digression.

The Birth in 1885 and Generational Narration

Kalit's birth in Lattar Thakur's household is dated to 1885. The child's remarkable responsiveness to sound, habit of gazing at trees and introduction to English learning suggest possibilities for his future character. Yet the unusual indications at birth do not establish a deterministic law governing his entire life. The narrator presents the child's quick intelligence alongside the father's unease. The contrast leaves room for ethical development and later choices. A historical date anchors the family account, while the manner of telling keeps the child from becoming merely a foreordained symbol. Character is anticipated, not exhaustively known.

Three Doors of Language

Kalit learns to navigate English letters, Devanagari writing, Kaithi ledgers and oral genealogies. Such multilingual ability is not represented as a neutral store of knowledge. Variant spellings of a person's name across land records, revenue accounts and court papers can change the practical recognition of rights. Kalit's skill therefore promises assistance while also creating opportunities for control. Whoever can read another person's document becomes an intermediary; intermediacy may acquire authority over the person being helped. The novel locates this potential danger within a local world of land and administration, rather than treating linguistic competence as unconditionally emancipatory.

The Attraction of Writing and Moral Anxiety

Lattar is pleased by his son's intelligence but fears that a serpent-like cunning may develop within it. This is not a declaration of innate wickedness. It signals the uncertain ethical direction of an ability that could help a farmer understand a document or be used to alter the balance of ownership claims. The possible division within the child's future grows gradually in narrative time. The father's response turns a general warning about knowledge and power into a specific generational anxiety. By preserving the difference between capacity and action, the chapter resists a premature judgement on Kalit and opens a longer question about the uses of literacy.

The Different Durations of Paper and Soil

Lattar contrasts a bird's fleeting imprint in sand with a falsehood that may remain on paper for generations. The comparison unsettles any simple equation between permanence and truth. Durable writing need not be honest; an ephemeral trace in sand need not be meaningless. The life span of a medium and the veracity of what it communicates are separate matters. When an old land dispute returns in Nand's time as another scheduled hearing, the warning acquires historical depth: documents may endure for centuries while justice remains deferred. The chapter thereby turns a material contrast into a long-range commentary on administrative memory.

The Sensory Narrative of Smell

Lattar's warning about recognising the smell of wet paper, earth and money extends reading beyond sight and abstract intelligence. Smell becomes an ethical figure for discernment. It is not proposed as a scientific method of detecting corruption. Rather, an elder's sensory vocabulary expresses a responsibility to question the uses of documents. When Nand later senses silt and money in the death lists, the inherited saying acquires

new force within his own judgement. An ancestral admonition ceases to be merely a phrase remembered from childhood and becomes an inner voice guiding the interpretation of contemporary records.

Ba's Right to Listen

Ba cannot read the mixed Kaithi–Devanagari slip in its entirety, but she recognises its form and its place in the family's history. She listens to what the leaves seem to say, questions the ghosts and insists upon names rather than allowing dates to dominate. The narrative does not reduce her to an illiterate old woman. Her authority arises from long experience and attentive hearing, in a register different from that of official written papers. Nor does it make her infallible: her questions, doubts and need to wait remain visible. Listening is presented as a form of knowledge without being made a substitute for every factual inquiry.

The Ghost Assembly and the Form of Dialogue

Ba places the gamchha and the slip before Burhbā in Channa Grove and asks about a name. The exchange resembles a figurative court: an object is presented, questions follow, limits of knowledge are acknowledged, and the document becomes a first potential element in Nand's testimony. Oral engagement replaces the authority usually signified by an official seal. Yet the ghosts' replies do not reveal the worker's complete identity. The scene offers an ethical direction for inquiry, not a verdict. Its narrative force lies in the transformation of family possessions into matters demanding public remembrance.

Crossing a Social Boundary Imposed on Women

The observation that women do not ordinarily enter the grove at night is immediately followed by Ba's entrance. The juxtaposition brings her independent agency into view within a restrictive gendered convention. The ghosts recognise her as a peer because she knows grief. This exceptional recognition does not establish that every woman in the village now enjoys equal freedom or public authority. Ba is both an exception to an existing rule and a challenge to that rule's legitimacy. Her movement into the grove is thus a concrete scene of agency, not a broad but unsupported declaration that social inequality has disappeared.

An Interval of Five Generations

Lattar, Kalit, Ba, Nand and the child Aruni form a long chain of transmitted memory. The chapter joins two rivers and multiple generations in one narrative moment, but not through complete biographies of everyone concerned. Objects, remembered words and recurring names permit the narration to cross considerable gaps. Nand

may act under the influence of an ancestor's warning without having seen its original speaker. The result hovers between magical hereditary continuity and the more ordinary processes through which social habits are passed on by telling and listening. The genealogy is meaningful as transmission, not as an unrestricted claim of direct experiential knowledge.

Three Forms of an "Unknown Boundary"

In the land dispute the river erases a boundary that the paper refuses to acknowledge. In the labour tragedy, water takes a body while the register does not recognise its name. In court, hearing dates continue to arrive while justice is postponed. Burhbā's conversation links these as related forms of an "unknown boundary." The recurrence turns the account beyond lineage towards a long history of administrative erasure. Nevertheless, the particular institutional processes of different eras remain distinct. The analogy illuminates their common problem without proving that every legal or economic mechanism has been identical across centuries.

The Child Aruni's View and a Future Reader

Young Aruni remembers the colour of the gamchha without yet grasping its historical significance. The narrator alludes to a future urban scene and questions emerging after a film. This forward reference distinguishes the child's limited perception from the narrator's knowledge of later narrative possibilities. A remembered colour may eventually connect a public political image with an issue surrounding death, but such a scene has not occurred here. The child's partial understanding restrains any hurried reconstruction of what the future must contain. In narrative terms, a sensory detail is laid down as a thread that can acquire meaning only later.

The Story's Distinct Geographical Links

Saurath, the shadow of Partapur, Darbhanga, the Kamala-Balan, the Ganges and news from colonial towns broaden the scale of the village's world. Marriage practices, field boundaries and systems of colonial documentation converge in this geography. Yet mentioning a place is not the same as staging a fully developed event there. The narrator sometimes supplies only a sign or reference and elsewhere dwells on an extended scene. This uneven distribution of narrative density should be recognised, rather than treating every named location as an autonomous subplot. The chapter's geography functions as a series of pathways by which local life meets larger institutions.

Assessment of the Chapter

The Village on the Right Bank asks where a story truly begins: in a river accident, or in the household where a torn gamchha waits for a name. Lattar's warning, Kalit's linguistic abilities, Ba's insistence on hearing and Nand's formal petition belong to one long structure of inheritance. The chapter excels in connecting generations. Its limitation is the narrator's occasional tendency to explain moral connections so directly that the reader has less freedom to infer them from scenes. Yet the gamchha, the chest and its opening clasp provide a tangible centre around which the many shifts in time can be organised.

Critical Section 104 | Original Chapter 3 — The Account of the Splash

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

Waiting Begins with the Receipt of an Application

The chapter opens with the official stamp “Received.” Its immediate effect is to expose the distance between receipt and being heard. Nand submits an application, but a clerk jokes that the higher the paper travels through the system, the longer it will take to return. Bureaucratic time thereby becomes dramatic material. The brief sound of the splash at the river expands into a prolonged period of waiting for an account of what happened. The story has moved from the instant of an accident to the comparatively slow duration of files, offices and postponement. The contrast makes delay part of the event's continuing consequences rather than a neutral interval after it.

The Title Transformed: From Number to Face

An “account” normally suggests enumeration, but Nand tries to connect bodies with their families, villages, shoes and names. A number alone cannot restore the different experiences that precede the deaths. The chapter thus distinguishes Nand's act of accounting from an exclusively financial or administrative ledger. His writing seeks to preserve traces of lives before they were reduced to mortality figures. Yet the text also acknowledges that certain names remain incomplete. The account is a moral necessity, not an omniscient register. Its very incompleteness makes further conversation with families and scrutiny of records necessary.

The Office as a Constructed Scene

The tin roof, polished development signboard, minister's photograph, image of the foreign company's respectable public face, blue safety ledger and tea table furnish the office as a political stage. Officials speak briefly while files seem to act for much longer. Papers are lifted, pages turned, translations adjusted and meetings adjourned. These small operations establish the rhythm through which institutional power acts upon vulnerable people. The office's material arrangement reveals a system more effectively than a single declaration by a corrupt official could. The reader watches administration as a succession of performed gestures, making the paperwork itself an active part of the plot.

Meaning Lost in Translation

A foreign consultant's description of casualties as “manageable” becomes the softer assertion that the situation is under control. Risks to local workers are recast as workers failing to obey rules, and some statements are not translated at all. This is not represented merely as the unavoidable imperfection of changing languages. The differences diminish the force of the original claims in a particular direction. Because the narrative lets readers hear both the initial wording and its adapted form, readers possess more information than some participants in the meeting. The imbalance creates dramatic irony. Translation becomes an instrument of institutional representation rather than a transparent bridge between speakers.

Bisesar's Wife and the Testimony of a Shoe

In a tarpaulin shelter, Bisesar's wife shows the shoe that remains of her husband. Confronted with the administrative assertion that he simply left the job, this object raises a forceful question. The surviving shoe does not independently prove every detail of the accident, but it destabilises the claim that absence requires no further inquiry. The woman presents the object herself; she is not merely a pitiful figure viewed through Nand's compassion. Her direct question becomes the scene's emotional centre. Through her action, a seemingly insignificant possession acquires a force that the official list has been arranged to exclude.

Unequal Naming in the Labour Camp

The temporary settlement contains labourers from Bihar, Odisha, Bengal, Assam, the Nepal borderlands and other distant regions. Many are identified by caste, appearance, bodily features or nicknames instead of an individually established name. The practices reveal the workers' social invisibility and the unequal terms by which employers and fellow labourers may recognise them. Nand's effort to ask for personal names breaks with the reduction of persons to readily usable categories. It also raises a question about his own authority as investigator: how fully are workers able to tell their own stories, rather than having their identities reconstructed through the benevolent attention of an engineer?

The Attendance of Women: Recording Invisible Labour

Names such as Munia, Sarayu, Phulkali, Rajni, Jamuna and Dhanesari appear on coconut leaves. The office, however, classifies these women as family members instead of recording their labour as paid employment. Nand objects that whoever carries sacks is a worker. The scene explicitly contests an administrative definition of labour that excludes women whose bodies perform the work. At the same time, a magical appearance of names

on leaves and the actual correction of an official attendance register are distinct processes. The episode reveals a conflict and asserts the necessity of recognition; it does not show the entire bureaucratic exclusion already repaired.

Nand's Ethical Test

Shashibhushan Dev's envelope, the prospect of promotion and the prestige of the project provide inducements for silence. Nand does not open the envelope. His reaction to its smell links the present scene to ancestral warnings about paper and money. The refusal risks making him a spotless hero, yet subsequent threats and the trembling of his hand preserve his vulnerability. Courage emerges as a decision made while afraid, not as the absence of fear. The narratively important fact is the refusal and what it costs emotionally. The passage does not need a fabricated account of the envelope's precise contents to establish its pressure upon him.

Letters and Threats as Opposed Forms of Writing

Nand writes applications while the institution sends warnings. The threatening letter orders him to stop recording names; he responds by pasting it into his diary. Writing is thus available to both the powerful and those resisting them. On one side it can remove names and impose silence; on the other it can preserve the traces of attempted silencing. The hostile document becomes a piece of evidence within the archive it sought to destroy. This reversal turns writing into action within the story. The contest cannot be reduced to paper being either inherently just or inherently oppressive: its function depends on who writes, what is omitted and what survives.

The One-Day Performance of an Inquiry Committee

An inquiry committee arrives for a daytime inspection. Workers have been told to remain silent; protective helmets appear for that particular day, while bereaved families are kept away. The public performance of safety is not an accurate reproduction of ordinary working conditions. Readers already know about dark shifts and wet ropes, so the committee's favourable conclusion is marked by dramatic irony. The scene exposes the manufacture of something that may subsequently circulate as “official evidence.” It is the difference between lived labour and a carefully arranged inspection that matters. The performance can create a report without establishing that the site was consistently safe.

The Rainy Night and Accelerated Time

Heavy rain returns. Paperwork ostensibly calls for work to stop, yet labour continues. Wind, the clatter of iron and the river's roar accelerate the prose

until another accident occurs. Nand's cry to halt work is lost before it can reach the people at risk. A sound that might be the name "Sarayu" enters the scene, but it is not an unequivocal confirmation of full identity. The narration holds readers on the threshold between sound, bodily action and uncertainty. Its tempo contrasts with the office's interminable delays. A process that could have been stopped in time is experienced as suddenly and violently irreversible.

The Moment of Tearing an Official Notice

Nand tears up a notice declaring that there was "no major loss." The act expresses more than personal anger: it marks the collapse of an earlier faith that official writing will necessarily describe what occurred. Yet destroying the notice does not automatically register the accident in a legal record. Nand gathers the fragments and preserves them in his diary. Rejection and archival care thus follow one another in a single double action. The language of denial is repudiated, but the material proof that it was issued is retained. The episode shows how resistance can require preserving the very document whose claim one refuses to accept.

Several Beginnings of the Diary

Bisesar, Chhotu and Sarayu begin to give The Account of the Splash its developing form. Chhotu's complete name remains to be found, and Sarayu's employment status is absent from the official record. Consequently, the diary is not a finished list but a document open to correction and extension. The first act of writing a name should not be mistaken for a completed judicial remedy. The narrative stages several beginnings as the diarist learns what needs to be recorded. The important quality of the book is its capacity to receive later evidence, amendment and additional testimony. Its unfinished form is part of its credibility.

The Reply of the Folk Song

The boatman's lament at the end resists an instruction merely to count splashes and calls instead for counting families. Events and possessions encountered in prose become a public refrain. The song is not simply a second summary of the incidents; it transforms private grief into a form that others may voice. Nevertheless, the emotional coherence of the song differs from the unresolved uncertainties of the administrative file. Its public utterance can honour families while still leaving crucial names and facts to be established. Treating that honour as complete victory would flatten the relationship between lyric solidarity and the painstaking investigation the chapter has begun.

Overall Critical Judgement

The chapter's main movement is from a momentary accident to an extended struggle over records. Softened translations, compensation politics, absent women workers, attempted bribery, threats and the diary form a connected sequence. The narrative moves between offices, camps, the village and the spectral stage, with the splash as their recurring sound. Its central artistic achievement is to give written documents active roles within the events. A risk remains in the narrator's frequent explicit moral interpretation, which can narrow the space for independent judgement. Concrete scenes—the shoe, the deceptive inspection and the torn notice—nevertheless resist reduction to statements of principle.

Critical Section 105 | Original Chapter 4 — Thirty Names, Three Hundred Bodies

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Numerical Conflict of the Title

“Thirty” and “three hundred” do not stand as two equally verified enumerations. The official death list stops at thirty, while Nand's wider inquiry, workers' recollections and villagers' protests suggest losses reaching three hundred. The title converts the discrepancy into a struggle over who may be named, rather than a problem of arithmetic alone. Reducing the reported number can remove human injury from the realm of recognised responsibility. Yet accepting the larger claim as already final would likewise disregard the story's continued doubts, missing identities and work of corroboration. The discrepancy must remain visible in its different evidentiary levels.

Sarayu's Reversed Documentary Existence

Sarayu carries sacks under her dead husband's name. He continues to appear in the wage records while the living woman whose labour is performed remains absent. This inversion brings together gender, widowhood, employment and the authority to name. Her particular circumstances are more precise than the general category “female labourer.” The economically active body and the documented worker have been separated, with injustice occupying the gap between them. Correcting the record would mean more than adding one entry; it would challenge the definition by which labour is recognised. The chapter makes this exclusion intelligible through one sharply drawn person and practice.

An Alternative Alphabet of Objects

Bisesar's shoe, Chhotu's gamchha, Sarayu's bracelet, Munia's slate and Dhanesari's bowl are small remains of labouring lives. The story calls them evidence, but they have a second narrative function: each becomes a sensory centre of memory around a missing or injured body. They recall bodily habits, work and relationships with relatives. Their admissibility within a formal court remains contested or unresolved. To equate their literary presence automatically with legal proof would remove the chapter's important tension. They matter because they insist that identifiable lives existed before any institution accepted or rejected a claim concerning them.

The Gradual Pace of Nand's Inquiry

By morning there are forty-nine names; by the third day seventy-two; within a week one hundred and seven. The changing counts give the search a measurable duration. The full record does not materialise through magic in a single instant. Some names are complete, while others remain partial, reduced to nicknames or clues about a village. Such admissions make Nand's diary a credible narrative device. Amid the powerful symbolic imagery, the ordinary work of collecting, revisiting and correcting particulars remains indispensable. Its deliberately slow rhythm makes the reader experience the effort involved in resisting bureaucratic absence.

The Irony of Orderly Columns

The official list presents clean columns for serial number, father, village, approximate age and compensation status. Its visual neatness appears authoritative. Yet Bisesar's father's name is wrong, and working women are missing altogether. The contrast between a well-organised page and the violence of omitted information questions documentary credibility itself. Readers learn that orderly presentation is not a guarantee of truthful representation. The point exceeds the personal misconduct of individual officials. The printed form helps establish the appearance of certainty and thereby conceals how much social experience has been excluded from the very categories it is designed to organise.

The Victim's Counterquestion

At the compensation distribution, Bisesar's wife asks about Chhotu and Sarayu before accepting her own envelope. She connects a possible individual benefit to the exclusion of others. Nand must acknowledge the legitimacy of her question, which shifts the centre of the gathering away from an official ceremony of payment. Officials would prefer to treat a disbursement as the closure of a case; the woman insists upon the names of people whom that ceremony leaves unrecognised. Collective ethical concern thus grows directly from individual grief, not from a slogan imposed upon it. Her question makes the administrative boundary of the event visible.

The Camera and the Manufacture of a “Smile”

In the heat and glare, a woman narrows her eyes. The resulting press photograph is interpreted as showing her smiling. The scene offers a particularly sharp criticism of visual narration. Readers know the actual conditions of the instant; the public image supplies a different meaning. Her face becomes evidence of administrative success, although she has not consented to that reading of her expression. The woman loses control over the public story attached to her own appearance. Camera, spectator and

authority become a triangular arrangement of power. The narrative makes the discrepancy concrete rather than merely asserting that photographs may deceive.

Counting in the Grove and the Collective Voices of the Dead

Under Burhbā's direction, the rules of spectral kabaddi change: one must ask for an account as well as the name of anyone caught. An official voice declares thirty sufficient, but counting resumes at thirty-one. This is a magical image of collective resistance to imposed numerical closure. The dead refuse to remain the sum permitted by an administrative list. Their voices dramatise a social protest, but the count made in a ghostly game is not itself the final finding of an official death inquiry. Its narrative function is to make the suppressed multitude audible, not to abolish all questions of evidence and identification.

The Global Network Behind Construction

The bridge belongs not merely to steel supports and the riverbank but also to banks, insurance, foreign finance, project management and the publicity surrounding a ministerial inauguration. A short sequence of references makes the local labour disaster part of a larger institutional world. The chapter does not provide an exhaustive financial history of each organisation in that network. Its principal literary task is to insert an endangered and obscured worker's body into the polished public landscape of development. The critic should keep the difference between an evoked global structure and particular transactions demonstrably described by the narrative.

The Project Director's Redefinition of “Truth”

Shashibhushan Dev dismisses truth as a philosophical term separate from construction management. Nand answers by invoking the bodies buried, figuratively, in the foundations. Their disagreement is not a detached academic debate: labour deaths and the construction's material procedures remain its basis. Yet Nand's statement about bodies in the piers is a forceful literary accusation, not proof that every foundation physically contains a buried corpse. The language is intensified by grief. Its power depends on that intensity, while a precise reading still distinguishes rhetorical indictment from an independently recorded material fact.

The Locked File and Three Versions of a Sound

Nand's file is locked in a separate cupboard. A sound emerges at night. The watchman hears an ominous disturbance, the office explains it as a rat, and Nand hears a name. One audible occurrence receives three different interpretations. The narrator does not invariably fix a single physical cause;

listeners' fears, interests and memories become the subject. This makes the scene an example of narrative plurality rather than a simple uncertainty to be corrected. Its competing readings carry the institutional conflict into the material world of the file cabinet and demonstrate how the same sign can function differently for those who encounter it.

Official Justice and the Idea of a People's Court

In response to Bisesar's wife's question, Nand says that a court begins wherever a dead person's family stands up. This is an ethical and figurative court, not a literal replacement for the legal judiciary. The statement asserts that suffering deserves a public hearing and that recognition cannot be confined to the permission of an office. The gap between such moral justice and an institutional ruling nevertheless remains. It is precisely this gap that makes later legal struggle necessary. If a declaration of popular moral authority were already equivalent to enforceable judgement, the story's continuing conflicts over records and compensation would have ended here.

Numbers and the Objects of Memory

Alongside numbers, Nand records shoes, gamchhas, laughter, coughs and signs of the places from which people came. In this method the figure becomes an index to traces of distinct lives. The details resist interchangeability, reminding readers that the people named cannot be wholly reconstructed from an abstract category. Yet assembling fragments does not restore an entire human being. The narrative acknowledges that limit. The ethical responsibility of memory is not to abolish absence, but to prevent the reasons for absence and the relationships surrounding the missing person from themselves disappearing.

The Form of an Incomplete Victory

The chapter ends with the official register still fixed at thirty and Nand's much broader collection continuing to grow. The conflict has not been resolved at once. Some families receive compensation, while many remain outside the recognised category. The public ceremony projects success; private memory retains grief. Such unequal results prolong the tragic duration rather than producing a decorative victory. The reader is made to feel the necessity of subsequent action. The competing lists are not merely different totals, but rival narratives with different consequences for households, workers and institutions.

Overall Assessment of the Section

Thirty Names, Three Hundred Bodies brings four systems into conflict: enumeration, naming, images and written records. Sarayu, Bisesar's wife,

Nand, the officials, the camera and the ghosts present different aspects of an unequal field of evidence. The chapter's achievement lies in restoring social narrative to the act of counting. Its limitation is that the individual verification of the larger claim of three hundred remains incomplete in the text. Preserving that gap is part of critical fidelity. The unfinished count becomes a major ethical and narratological tension, compelling readers to ask both who is missing and who has been empowered to define the list.

Critical Section 106 | Original Chapter 5 — The Crocodile of Court Dates

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From the Visible River to the Invisible Court

Water at a river landing can be seen, but the “water of court dates” has no comparable visible form. The chapter shifts the crocodile image from a living creature to the seemingly endless postponement of institutional justice. Immediate bodily catastrophe becomes a slow, often silent depletion of lives. The ages of surviving relatives increase while dates for hearing the case continue to multiply. This asymmetry makes waiting itself a form of violence within the narrative. The metaphor is effective because it is anchored in the irreversible passage of time experienced by families, rather than being only a moral label applied to the judiciary.

Repeated Hearings and Narrative Duration

The first through seventh hearing dates are accompanied by different reasons for postponement: unavailable records, a judge's leave, a lawyers' strike, transfer of a file and the demand for expert assistance. The reasons vary, but the result recurs. Such repetition deliberately slows the narrative. Readers do not merely receive information that the case has been delayed; the sequence asks them to experience exhaustion through successive failed occasions. Elapsed time affects more than Nand's determination. The biological lives of bereaved families continue to diminish. Institutional delay and personal mortality thereby become inseparable elements of the chapter's tragic temporal design.

Devkinandan Chaube: The Complexity of an Intermediary

The lawyer Chaube initially hesitates before the objects Nand brings, then helps prepare the petition. He seeks a possible passage through the constraints of legal language, while Nand continues to question the inadequacy of those constraints. Calling Chaube merely a lifeless representative of the system would ignore his discomfort, respect and fear. His professional role has its own ethical tensions. Legal translation makes it possible for private grief to enter an institutional procedure, yet gaining entry is not the same as receiving judgement. The chapter preserves this difference, giving the lawyer a mediating function without turning him into the immediate author of a successful verdict.

Recasting the Case in Legal Language

The petition names revision of the list of the dead, an independent inquiry, recognition of women workers, compensation fraud and failures of safety precautions. These categories reorganise experiences of loss as claims upon public institutions. Bisesar's shoe remains an intimate remnant of grief, but the petition places the wider conditions surrounding it within the language of responsibility and examination. Such translation changes the form of the story. It is not described as a completed victory. Filing the petition opens another stage, with different audiences, rules and opportunities for obstruction. The narrative shows how testimony must be altered to gain institutional hearing without assuming that its emotional truth will be fully preserved.

The Accusation of Being an "Emotional Engineer"

The foreign company's advocate brings up Nand's transfer and personal grief to undermine the credibility of his account. The rhetorical objective is to change his identity from a witness of unsafe labour into that of a disgruntled employee. Readers have already seen the earlier scenes at the site and can therefore detect what this rival characterisation selects or omits. The court becomes a field of conflicting narratives, not a place where truth automatically becomes transparent. The episode demonstrates that a dispute over facts can be fought through competing biographies of the person who brings those facts to light.

The Developing Legal Career of Batuknath Hariharan

Batuknath's polished speech, skill at prolonging hearings and growing professional reputation create an inverse arc of development. Abilities that could have served vulnerable people are used instead to exhaust opponents. Describing the court as haunted anticipates the ethical deterioration associated with his later role. Nevertheless, it would be wrong to attribute every adjournment to him alone. The narrative lists autonomous obstacles within the judicial system. His individual agency and the institution's wider failures intersect but do not collapse into a single cause. This distinction makes the account more than a simple portrayal of a uniquely wicked lawyer.

The Stolen File and the Story of Copies

In Chaube's office, the order of pages changes although the lock has not been broken. A photograph of the shoe vanishes, and the sheet carrying Sarayu's thumb impression is exchanged. Violence enters the archive through rearrangement and removal rather than direct physical assault. A second copy kept with Ba helps protect the record against loss. The instruction to leave one copy with one's mother joins maternal memory to

the practical safeguard of duplication. The novel therefore values not only extraordinary remembrance but ordinary backup procedures. The conflict over a file has consequences because the possibility of later testimony depends upon preserving what its contents originally recorded.

Satyavrat Mehta's Unstable Position

Satyavrat enters in an official legal or governmental capacity while privately recommending that Nand make several copies. He retains Sarayu's thumb-marked paper in his own diary. His public position and inward resistance are thus present together. He has not yet become a fully open witness against the system. Rather, his hesitation lays groundwork for a later ethical decision. The narrator builds character through a small act of preservation and a divergence between institutional role and personal judgement. The seeming modesty of the gesture is central: an archived page may matter even when the person keeping it remains outwardly silent.

The Return of Bisesar's Shoe

Water enters the storehouse, and drops fall from Bisesar's shoe with the sound chhapāk. The accident returns acoustically without the dead person returning to life. The shoe changes from surviving object to a kind of sound-bearing narrator. To a storehouse worker it is rubbish; to Nand it is testimony. These contrasting names reveal different systems of valuation. The scene does not entirely separate its magical feeling from an ordinary physical environment, leaving room for more than one reading of the sound. Its significance is the persistence of memory in a place organised to store and classify discarded objects.

Social Time and the Time of the Court

Judges, clerks and government advocates change; Ba grows old, children of the dead become adults, and some family members die. The same red tape appears to remain on the file. The narrative contrasts the institution's outward continuity with irreversible losses in the lives waiting upon it. The seeming stability of legal procedure does not preserve the lives of those seeking justice. Through parallel changes the chapter gives concrete content to the violence of delayed time. The case can remain technically open even as those who first demanded answers become unable to see its conclusion. Duration is therefore an ethical condition, not simply chronological background.

Children's Collective Reading of Names

Nand teaches children to recite Bisesar, Sarayu, Munia, Dhanesari, Bholtun and other names. The official list remains at thirty while the children's

count reaches towards three hundred. Song, play and education now meet in one communal activity. What began as a private diary becomes an exercise carried by multiple voices. Yet repeating names does not independently verify every disputed death or establish a complete account of each life. Collective memory requires opportunities for questions and correction as well as rehearsal. The scene's value lies in its transfer of responsibility to younger speakers, while the difference between memorial performance and evidentiary examination remains intact.

Planting a Threat in Earth

A second threatening message is found inside Bisesar's shoe. Rather than burn it, Ba buries it in a tulsi pot. The hostile piece of paper becomes part of a domestic ritual of memory. This is not presented as a formal legal filing but as a symbolic act of resistance: fear's trace is kept rather than simply destroyed. The dead worker's shoe, the living witness's vulnerability and the earth of the plant share a small scene. The gesture follows the novel's longstanding conviction that remembrance requires preserving difficult marks. It also supplies a visual counterpoint to the locked and manipulated files of official institutions.

A Foreshadowing of Digital Fraud

Future plots involving Chandrapal Batra's online entanglements, Batuknath's drawer and Satyavrat's private pages are signalled from the court corridor. Their mention broadens the temporal structure of the narrative. Yet these projected developments should not be treated as already completed crimes at the present point in the story. A source-faithful reading retains the distinction between narrated occurrence, inference and anticipation. The transformation of the crocodile from the court's hearing dates towards the digital screen creates an interwoven structure across chapters without abolishing the different times at which its strands emerge.

Judicial Language in Ghostly Kabaddi

The ghosts exchange phrases about court, dates, missing records, preserved copies, time running out and memory remaining. The dialogue is compact and almost theatrical. The shadow of living Nand enters the game while his physical body remains involved in legal struggle. Official phrases, ordinarily dry and repetitive, become rhythmic lines of communal reply. The game gives an audible form to the cruelty of bureaucratic recurrence. It is not literally a hearing in a recognised court; its work is to make a structure of oppression imaginable through the bodily rules of play and the voices of those excluded from formal procedure.

The Chapter's Ending and Critical Judgement

The file may close, but the story does not. Against ribbons cut at inaugurations, applause and newspaper claims of development stand Nand's continuing diary and the songs of children. The Crocodile of Court Dates presents social time as something capable of devouring lives. It avoids becoming only an abstract allegory by repeatedly returning to real losses among families, workers and the elderly. The main achievement is to make institutional waiting a character-dependent narrative experience. Its critical limitation is that responsibility for particular delays cannot be distributed equally among all participants in the legal process. Distinct causes remain even when the consequences converge.

Critical Section 107 | Original Chapter 6 — Ethics at Harvard

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Abrupt Global Expansion of Narrative Space

After Channa Grove, the Ganges bridge and the Indian court, the narrative moves abruptly to a bright hall at Harvard. Snow falls outside; within are warm light, name badges and shining screens. The shift places the earlier tragedy of labour within an international setting of institutional prestige. Harvard is not simply a contrasting picture of wealth. The very bridge whose workers were lost is being displayed there as an instance of responsible development. Village memory and a university's public archive therefore bear different histories of the same object, although the two settings do not initially recognise their relationship. The sudden geographical expansion sharpens the conflict over representation.

Ira Aruni's Perspective

Ira sits towards the rear, observes the surroundings and hears the remembered sound of chhapāk. The scene's contradictions are largely filtered through her experience. Though she belongs to a generation born abroad, she is not a passive recipient of inherited folklore. She brings family memory, digital records and questions asked in the present into contact. Her unease and inquiry develop over time. The narrative does not grant her a complete answer before she speaks. Such uncertainty makes her credible as an investigating character and allows readers to follow the movement from an inherited recollection towards a public challenge grounded in what she is still trying to establish.

Broom's Corporate Image and the Deception of Time

Edward Broom's business appears under a succession of names associated with infrastructure, healthcare, defence consultancy, digital payments and ethics institutions. His public claim that names may change while values remain constant collides with the remembered bridge tragedy. Corporate rebranding becomes a series of masks within the plot. Yet reference to these organisations should not be converted into independently proven criminal conduct by every named entity. What the fiction makes visible is a struggle between the narrative of global reputation and the uneven survival of evidence about an older disaster. The reader must separate the force of the juxtaposition from facts that remain unestablished.

The Dramatic Work of the Fourth Slide

The fourth slide in Broom's presentation displays the old Indian bridge and claims of minimal accidents and independent safety testing. Ira remembers another river and another account of deaths. One projected image thus carries two opposed meanings: success for the sponsor, erased loss for the inheritor of memory. The slide becomes the scene's central narrative object. Readers should neither take the corporate image as a transparent statement of fact nor assume that Ira's initial suspicion constitutes the entire investigation's conclusion. Their collision generates a demand for comparison, documents and answers. The same picture cannot be read adequately without knowing who is speaking through it.

A Public Question and the Displacement of an Answer

Ira asks for the actual number of bridge deaths. Broom responds in the language of institutional principles, while director Elena Graves redirects the concrete inquiry towards "broader responsibility." Authority operates here not only by refusing speech but by shifting the subject of the reply. When Ira presses the reliability of the local records, the hall's cultivated atmosphere briefly becomes uncomfortable. The confrontation remains one of questions and evasive responses within a polite public setting. No direct confession of a specific crime occurs on the stage. The scene exposes a rhetorical practice by which a particular factual demand can be absorbed into a generalised ethical vocabulary.

The Magical Image of Water Seeping Into the Hall

While Broom speaks of standards and ethics, drops of water, sand and lines resembling Devanagari appear upon the table. These uncanny details pierce the external cleanliness of the seminar room with the sediment of the Ganges. Water becomes a visual language for the moral contradiction that the public presentation seeks to suppress. The fantastic event does not provide a literal courtroom statement by Sarayu or by a dead worker. Its narrative power is to make repressed memory intrude unexpectedly into a space organised for polished institutional argument. A magical register and a documentary question work alongside one another without becoming interchangeable kinds of evidence.

Raghav Somani and the Parallel Scene of Surveillance

As ethical questions are discussed onstage, Raghav Somani receives confidential phone messages. Brief notices concerning questions about the old bridge slide and a warning to the India team establish a private channel of control alongside the public discussion. Ira's challenge is open; Raghav's response moves information through a more guarded network. The reader is shown more than Ira knows at that instant, but the

consequences of every message are still withheld. This distribution of information creates a sense of surveillance. It also establishes the contrast between asking for an accountable public explanation and attempting to manage the circulation of a potentially inconvenient question.

Chandrapal Batra and Batuknath in a Distant Network

Chandrapal's laptop holds material about the old bridge alongside gaming applications, mule accounts, threatening digital-arrest messages and new debts. Batuknath addresses a wedding gathering about the rule of law while a questionable envelope lies on the table. Both scenes are brief, yet each exposes a gap between a public identity and a more obscure activity. Their quick reactions after Ira's question suggest a narrative connection. The precise criminal chain tying every transaction and person together has not, however, been fully established by these glimpses. The scenes function as parallel indications, preparing later investigation rather than completing a prosecution on the page.

Satyavrat's "If" and the Ethics of Silence

In Delhi, Satyavrat reads an official brief and notes that the original list of names should be requested, but adds the qualification "if available." The small word opens his inner conflict. Pressure associated with government service, the long history of the file and his private judgement coexist. Rather than announcing heroic defiance, the narrator traces dissatisfaction within guarded bureaucratic phrasing. Twice underlining the need for verification becomes the seed of a decision whose full consequences remain to be seen. The character's moral movement is presented as procedural and hesitant. His restraint should not be mistaken for either completed whistleblowing or complete indifference to the missing names.

Global Criticism and the Email from Home

Ira finds an old email from Ba and scanned pages associated with Nand Aruni. At this moment, spoken family memory becomes available through digital reproduction. A story rooted in the village can be read again within the university library. Ira studies the documents but does not thereby claim to have established every legal conclusion. She writes to a professor asking that a public question be raised. The sequence is carefully measured: opening the message, recognising a connection and preparing a question. It builds the character's purpose through acts of reading and comparison, rather than granting sudden certainty through the mere discovery of an old scan.

The Arrival of an Unnamed Digital Dead Person

A new spirit appears in Channa Grove holding a mobile phone. This person is said to have died not in a river but in circumstances involving gaming, debt, threats delivered by someone posing as police and social fear. The crocodile motif extends from physical water burial to the danger of digital humiliation and coercion. Even Pānidubbi falls silent before a form of suffering unfamiliar to the older spectral community. The scene stages the limits of inherited folk knowledge: the ghosts themselves must learn to comprehend new modes of violence. Nevertheless, the magical presence is not a substitute for a complete procedural account of the death.

"Percentage" Against "Name"

The word "percentage" glows upon a dark screen in the ghosts' gathering. Hulāsi calls it hunger rather than a name. Financial enumeration is placed in stark opposition to the recognition of particular people. The community of the dead seeks to add names, whereas the network of profit calculates percentages. This visual contrast restates a central symbol of the novel. Yet the precise rates, contractual terms and transactions behind the economic references remain incomplete. The metaphor makes the moral structure of the scene perceptible without serving as an independent financial audit. The reader's task is to recognise what the image reveals and what still requires documentary examination.

The Simultaneity of Three Cities

The closing sequence presents Ira awaiting a response at Harvard, Satyavrat preparing to seek original records in Delhi and Chandrapal investigating an old family connection. These activities occur within the same dawn but have different immediate objectives. Garh Narikela remains the shared centre of memory through which they can be understood together. The narrative uses parallel editing to make geographically distant acts feel simultaneous. That technique does not mean that physical distance or differences of power have disappeared. It brings the separate spaces into a common field of significance while retaining the institutional and personal conditions that divide them.

The Folk Song and Ethical Irony

The concluding song places snowfall, the bright lecture hall and blood imagined in the bridge foundations within one utterance. The applause of the stage is confronted by a call to remember names. The song transforms the contradiction already developed in the narrative into a public voice of mourning. Its accusation is more impassioned than the comparatively gradual documentary process represented by Ira's questions and Satyavrat's file requests. The critic must recognise both levels. The song's anger is a

genuine aspect of the work's narrative design, but not every accusation expressed poetically has already been established by a court or comprehensive investigation.

Overall Assessment of the Chapter

Ethics at Harvard expands the novel's geography and its arrangement of voices with unusual force. One screen exhibits the Ganges bridge as a monument to corporate prestige, while another preserves scanned pages of loss. The rhetoric of global ethics meets Ira's narrow but consequential demand for a death count. Delhi's official files, Batra's communications and the digital ghost in Channa Grove bring multiple centres into the narrative. The achievement is the dramatic opposition of representations that circulate globally with memories that have been neglected locally. The limitation is an occasional tendency to repeat the ethical contradiction through overt symbolism, when Ira's quiet email may convey it more movingly through restraint.

Critical Section 108 | Original Chapter 7 — The Price of Breath

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

A Narrative of Drowning in Air Rather Than Water

In "The Price of Breath," the earlier pattern of water burial changes its medium. No body needs to fall into a river: illness, the atmosphere, hospitals and the shortage of oxygen now threaten life. Pānidubbi's question about what disease can drown a person in air marks the inadequacy of the community's older vocabulary of aquatic danger. The chapter is not merely a documentary history of the pandemic. It enlarges the narrative meaning of "drowning" while retaining the material differences between water and breath. Air and water are connected as conditions of living, not confused as identical physical causes. The critical task is to trace the expansion of the governing image without reducing distinct deaths to one mechanism.

The Emptied Public Time of 2020

Stopped trains, deserted roads, spring flowers behind windows and distant ambulance sirens construct a collective experience of pandemic time. Where the preceding chapter of prolonged judicial proceedings made waiting seem almost motionless, fear of infection here accelerates events. People are confined to homes while news arrives at many different speeds through mobile phones. Empty streets contrast with crowded hospitals, revealing unequal capacities to act even during a shared emergency. This is the chapter's public temporal setting, but individual characters experience it differently. The narrative gains force by bringing those differences into a seemingly universal period of isolation; the social meaning of the same year cannot be exhausted by a single emblem of lockdown.

Aruni Nandan and a Child's Question

In Delhi, Aruni Nandan cannot find an easy answer to his daughter Ananya's question about masks. The girl imagines whether ghosts might wear them; the father sees living faces half concealed. Public catastrophe enters the novel through a small exchange between parent and child. Her question is not a simplistic explanation of the epidemic but a fresh point of entry from a younger generation. Aruni's silence also matters: it is not merely lack of factual knowledge but the weight of an experience for which a reassuring answer is unavailable. The domestic dialogue slows the

expansive pandemic panorama and reminds the reader that new historical circumstances alter how familiar words, bodies and faces are recognised.

Ba's Warning About the Category "Other"

Ba urges that deaths involving disease, hospital exclusion, lack of oxygen and lack of medicine should be recorded separately. Her objection to the catch-all category "other" recalls the earlier disappearance of workers through administrative classification. The recurrence binds past erasures in labour records to the present struggle over mortality registers. Yet Ba's advice is a standard of responsible recording, not evidence that every pandemic death has been accurately classified. As before, the precise wording of an entry can decide whether an experience remains visible. This is an intergenerational transfer of documentary vigilance: lessons learned beside a bridge are redirected towards the hospital, while the distinctive causes of each loss must remain distinguishable.

The Changing Price of Beds and Cylinders

An empty bed displayed on a hospital website, refusal at its door, an intermediary demanding advance payment and the shifting price of oxygen provide the chapter with concrete incidents. The title emerges from their juxtaposition: a basic condition of life acquires a market price under pressure of fear. Human need and economic calculation are forced into the same scene. Nevertheless, the exhausted hospital guard is not automatically cast as a wholly malicious villain. The account leaves room for fatigue and institutional strain as well as exploitation. This distribution of human circumstances gives the moral criticism more texture than a simple opposition between innocent patients and uniformly ruthless individuals.

The Narrative Function of Gop Kumar's Accounting

Gop Kumar, an employee of Jeevanrekha Bio-Logistics, first appears between screens and billing entries rather than through a heroic entrance. He opens a file labelled "Breath Supply—Northern Region." A cylinder apparently supplied to several districts on the same day, regulators invoiced to a closed hospital and the signature of a deceased distributor form a series of specific discrepancies. Such details give an emerging conspiracy an intelligible documentary starting point. It is not merely an atmospheric suggestion of hidden darkness. At the same time, suspicious ledger entries are grounds for inquiry, not by themselves a complete adjudication of what happened. The understated work of opening and comparing files places narrative agency in patient scrutiny.

"NR-77": A Narrative Connection

A pandemic supply bill contains a reference to liability adjustment from the earlier bridge project. The code "NR-77" links two historical disasters without instantly explaining the whole connection. Gop first considers whether the entry might be a batch number, then examines old scans and notices a missing attachment. The order of discovery matters. A code becomes a narrative clue because the character tests possible meanings rather than arriving at complete knowledge in a single glance. The document itself is turned into an object of suspense. Criticism must resist treating the appearance of this shared code as sufficient proof of every transaction or criminal relationship that the story may eventually explore.

The Parallel Silences of Ira and Satyavrat

At Harvard, Ira receives an evasively courteous response; in Delhi, Satyavrat examines old files and pandemic-supply names during virtual hearings. Both acquire more information while remaining constrained by the institutions in which they work. Ira's questions arise from family memory; Satyavrat drafts a request for original contracts and payment lists. These are slow, procedural forms of resistance, not sudden transformations into all-powerful protagonists. Their parallel scenes suggest that moral responsibility may advance through checking records, drafting a careful request and refusing an easy answer. At this stage neither character has secured a conclusive institutional outcome, and their uncertainty is part of the narrative's continuing tension.

Chandrapal's Market in Fear

Chandrapal Batra sees opportunity in pandemic anxiety: bed packages, medicine packages, police passes and mule accounts. Messages linking him to Raghav Somani reduce economic predation to a compact language of timing; fear is commercially valuable while it lasts, and prices may fall when it subsides. The chapter makes a character's conception of time visible through prospective profit. Fear ceases to be a human emergency and becomes something to sell. But intention, planned offers, actual completed transactions and allegations later proven through investigation remain separate categories. This distinction is vital to a narratological account: the disclosure of a character's predatory calculation does not fill in every absent scene of its execution.

Ujjwal Jha's Entry into the Screen

Unemployed during lockdown, Ujjwal encounters an advertisement promising earnings from home. He stakes a small amount and wins for the first time. Devika Sah suspects danger in the game, but Ujjwal interprets her concern as ordinary fearfulness. An earlier prehistorical

foreshadowing is now taking the form of a present choice. The scene is significant because temptation begins in the concrete need for income and the credible experience of an initial gain. The chapter does not yet narrate Ujjwal's entire financial collapse or his ultimate fate. Its dramatic centre is the clash between a first reward and an unheeded warning—the beginning of a line of action, not its conclusion.

The Hidden Line in a File and the Missing List

Gop's screen places donation, overseas training, legal management and the old bridge under the heading of medical supply. A scanned note by Nand Aruni says that a separate list of women and unregistered workers was attached, but the attachment is missing. The absence is an active element in the plot: a document refers to evidence the researcher cannot yet inspect. A scanned page therefore does not establish that all the underlying names have been verified. Instead, it makes the missing material more urgent. The account of documentary inquiry proceeds through traces and omissions, not simply through the magical appearance of a complete archive.

Passwords and the Struggle over Memory

After Gop questions Chandrapal during a meeting, his access rights are curtailed. He has, however, already preserved a copy of the records. The old instruction to keep "one copy with Mother" is translated into the contemporary practice of making a digital backup. The medium changes while the struggle over who may keep a record remains continuous. Technology is neither unconditionally redemptive nor only an instrument of fraud. One party attempts to remove a file; another preserves a duplicate. This contrast makes the procedure itself narratively meaningful, though the existence of a saved copy must not be mistaken for proof that justice or comprehensive data security has already been secured.

The Unusual Entrance of Ishan Dutt

Gop receives a message whose sender is not identified. The narrator describes this as the first indication of Ishan Dutt—a man declared dead in official records who nonetheless transmits information. The contradiction between documentary death and a living act of communication carries the novel's older ghost narrative into the digital era. For Gop, anonymity initially warrants uncertainty; the narrator's mention of Ishan gives the reader information ahead of the character. The resulting asymmetry sustains suspense. The occurrence should not be flattened into either a fully explained technical scheme or an unquestionably supernatural resurrection: the source presents the conflict between the record and the new message before establishing all its circumstances.

Breath-Kabaddi and a New List of the Dead

In Channa Grove, the cry of "kabaddi" gives way to "breath," while the opposing voices pronounce "no bed," "no cylinder," "no medicine" and "payment first." The dead are added under "other." Hulāsi asks that the game be stopped, whereas Burhbā interprets it as practice in remembering future names. Their disagreement reveals a moral limit of communal ritual. How should spectral play respond to suffering that is still happening among the living? The narrative does not finally settle the problem. Instead, it keeps both resistance through remembrance and practical care for people in immediate danger in view. Ritual cannot be assumed to substitute for the urgent work of saving lives.

Overall Conclusion: From Water Burial to the Account of Breath

Gop's concluding thought—that the account of breath is not separate from the account of water burial—joins the bridge catastrophe to the pandemic's medical economy. The relation is structural and ethical, not an erasure of differences in the causes of death. The achievement lies in combining repeating documentary failures, an international economic network, inherited family memory and the precariousness of breathing within a multi-centred narrative. There is also a formal risk: numerous files, names and incidents appear to converge on one network rather swiftly. Missing attachments, Gop's uncertainty, Ira's unanswered questions and Ujjwal's first step into the trap nonetheless leave the subsequent testing of these connections open.

Closing Synthesis: The Interrelations of the First Eight Chapters of Part I

Across Critical Sections 101–108, the village's folk memory, spectral games, historical land records, the bridge disaster, official death lists, postponed justice, an international ethics lecture and pandemic supply chains progressively enter one another's fields. Water, names, leaves, a gamchha, a shoe, hearing dates, scanned pages and an oxygen cylinder belong to different circumstances yet develop a shared narrative resonance. The point is not that these objects are interchangeable; rather, the struggle between disappearance and remembrance reappears in different social settings. Later analysis of digital fraud, trafficking and privacy must build upon this opening structure while preserving the independent actions of characters and the differences between narrative levels.

Critical Section 109 | Original Chapter 8 — The Crocodile in the Screen

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

A New Category of Death Enters the Ghost World

When Burhbā, Hulāsi and Pānidubbi see the shadow of a screen in Channa Grove, the older language of water burial begins to name a modern technological danger. Pānidubbi speaks of drowning not in water but in the eyes. This does not cancel the history of real deaths in rivers; it subjects an inherited vocabulary to the pressure of a new crisis. The ghosts are trying to decide what such a death should be called. Consequently, the chapter begins not with technical specifications of a digital fraud but with a problem of cultural naming. The ancient symbolic repertoire is compelled to recognise forms of loss that it has not previously encountered.

Ujjwal's Domestic World

Ujjwal Jha sits on the veranda holding his phone. His mother cooks lentils, his father works over the farm's debts, and Devika sorts vegetables. These ordinary activities place the darkness of the screen within the household rather than in some remote, abstract criminal underworld. Economic worry, familial labour and hope for another source of income create the setting in which a fraudulent offer becomes attractive. Ujjwal is not introduced as inherently foolish or morally corrupt. His desire arises from a recognisable social circumstance. The domestic detail is essential to the criticism because it prevents an account of screen addiction from replacing the more complicated relation between family need, aspiration, persuasion and financial vulnerability.

The Narrative Trap of the First Winnings

In the “Raja-Rati” application, a stake of two hundred becomes five hundred, and then five hundred becomes two thousand. The sequence constructs confidence in the apparent reliability of the game. The purchase of sweets turns financial temptation into family happiness. Devika sees the possibility of a trap, but Ujjwal treats the early victories as evidence that the system works. Meanwhile, readers encounter private messages involving Chandrapal and Raghav that Ujjwal does not possess. This unequal distribution of information produces dramatic irony: an experience interpreted by one character as success appears to the reader as the

beginning of defeat. The effectiveness of the episode rests in the ordinary pleasure of a first gain.

The Criminal Network's Prearranged Time

Raghav's message outlines stages—a limit after five days, a bonus on the seventh and a credit line on the tenth. The criminal operators are plotting a sequence of future choices for another person. Ujjwal experiences the game as voluntary activity, while the network attempts to organise his forthcoming behaviour in advance. The narrator thus creates two concurrent temporal structures: planned inducement and the victim's partially informed experience. Still, it would be unjustified to assert that every stage was completed on exactly the proposed day unless the prose narrates that outcome. The message is evidence of intention and design. Its narrative importance lies in giving readers an anticipatory structure unavailable to Ujjwal.

Munna Paswan's Unsettled Moral Position

Munna accepts five thousand rupees to open an account without understanding its actual transactional purpose. His mother recognises the national emblem on a banknote and takes it as a sign of legitimacy. This juxtaposition exposes the possible misuse of familiar signs of state authority. Munna becomes useful to the financial network, but his degree of knowledge should not be equated with Chandrapal's more organised aims. The chapter differentiates an intermediary operating under economic temptation and incomplete information from the actors attempting to manage the scheme. Such differentiation is essential if the criticism is to avoid describing every account holder as equally culpable or every form of participation as fully informed consent.

The Architecture of a False Arrest

Ujjwal is ordered to shut himself in a room, keep his camera running and speak to nobody. Without prison walls, commands transmitted through a phone turn his private room into a place of confinement. The screen regulates speech, appearance and the passage of time. The authority of the impersonated official does not arise from a valid arrest but from fear of police, family shame and the apparent credibility of the voice. The so-called digital arrest is therefore presented as an internal narrative of gradually diminishing confidence. The physical room remains a room in the family home; psychologically, coercive instructions attempt to transform it into a cell.

Devika's Hearing and the Interrupted Conversation

Devika hears the threats from a concealed position near the roof. She has suspected that the game conceals danger, yet a direct and effective conversation with her brother does not begin in time. Ujjwal is silent precisely towards a person who might help him. This silence enables the coercive isolation sought by the fraudsters, but the weight of social fear must not be turned into an accusation against the victim. The episode also prepares Devika's later role as a narrator and witness for her brother. Her ability to hear, remember and eventually question what happened is established here before the story turns to the consequences of Ujjwal's isolation.

The Death Scene without Unnecessary Mystery

On the third day Ujjwal leaves home; his sandals are found by the Balan, and his body is discovered the following morning. The sequence is narrated with temporal clarity rather than dissolved into a mysterious ghostly entrance. The river is shallow, yet the metaphor of having already drowned inwardly gives the scene psychological weight. The discovery of the body is an event, while the network's causal involvement, the effects of threats and eventual legal accountability remain matters requiring separate assessment. The literary account exposes the complex experience leading towards death but does not itself constitute a court judgment. Its restraint about the visible sequence matters amid the broader use of supernatural imagery.

Competing Descriptions of the Death

Villagers speak of gambling, weakness and the mobile phone; police use the term “suicide”; the bank writes “suspicious transactions”; the application claims a breach of its rules. Devika disputes these selective descriptions and insists on the network's coercive conduct. A single death is therefore made to carry many institutional names. Readers, who have followed the preceding scenes, can perceive how each label selects some details and omits others. Devika's accusation has ethical force, but it should not be translated into an already completed legal finding. The plurality of accounts is itself a central narrative concern: classification competes with the lived history of threats, shame and financial manipulation.

A Name Reborn among the Ghosts

When Ujjwal reaches Channa Grove as a spirit, he initially cannot say his name; numbers for debt, interest, charges and guarantees fill the screen. Hulāsi urges him to leave the figures and speak the name that belongs to him. Once “Ujjwal” is uttered, the community receives him as a distinct

person. The naming cannot reverse his death. It can, however, remove the vocabulary of public disgrace and make a more humane form of mourning possible. The ghostly game becomes a school of listening, and the chapter's long-standing contrast between economic calculation and human recognition is enacted through one spoken word.

The Journey of the Broken Screen

Devika decides to send Ujjwal's damaged phone to the city, concealing it within the cover of a book. A private device becomes a potential bearer of testimony. Printed pages and digital messages now travel inside one material covering, recalling earlier shoes, gamchhas and paper scraps preserved after a disaster. The message "I am not a thief" is a dead person's self-description left within the narrative. Yet possession of the instrument does not mean that every item of its digital contents has been independently authenticated for legal purposes. The scene transforms an object associated with exploitation into one that may help preserve the subject's own words.

An Emotional Change in Gop's Accounting

After examining Ujjwal's file and Devika's video, Gop begins to experience the numbers in his spreadsheet as faces. Accounting moves from abstract comparison towards attentive hearing of grief. The change is not constructed through a grand declaration of heroism but through the encounter with a particular victim's story. The chapter places two demands upon documentary inquiry: exact classification of evidence and recognition of the human suffering the evidence concerns. Neither can replace the other. Gop's developing sensitivity broadens the narrative function of the ledger without licensing him to abandon questions of accuracy, provenance or the difference between suspicion and confirmed knowledge.

The Contradiction within "Voluntary"

At an online hearing, the game is described as skill-based and its users as voluntary participants. Satyavrat recalls similar institutional formulae: risk treated as part of development during bridge construction and "flexibility" invoked in emergency purchasing. The settings differ, but these expressions perform a related defensive task—turning contested conduct into apparently acceptable administration. The narrative questions the claim of free choice in the presence of intimidation and algorithmically staged rewards. Nevertheless, the literary comparison does not settle every issue a court must examine. Its function is to show how legitimacy can be produced through selected words while the reader remembers coercive circumstances omitted by those words.

Overall Assessment: From Numbers to Human Beings

Chapter 8 offers a concentrated staging of digital exploitation. Ujjwal's growing trust, his death, Devika's counter-account, Munna's partially informed involvement, Gop's examination of accounts and the ghosts' insistence on his name operate at distinct narrative levels. The achievement lies in moving behind the individualised charge of "gambling" to disclose systems of debt, fear and shame. One possible limitation is that messages between those planning the scheme explain its operation with unusual directness. The family cooking at the hearth and the broken telephone, however, return this large design to a particular, embodied life and prevent the episode from becoming only a schematic denunciation.

Critical Section 110 | Original Chapter 9 — The Market in Bodies

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From Documentary Evidence to the Trade in Bodies

After Ujjwal's death, the narrative turns to a different form of exploitation of vulnerable people. Employment, training, assistance and the public vocabulary of "women's dignity" serve as possible coverings for a coercive network. The conflict concerns attempts to dispossess a living woman of authority over her own body and the counter-action of insisting on her full name. This is not merely a repetition of the previous chapter. A network previously seen through loans and financial losses now threatens physical security and consent. The narrative gains a different ethical and sensory centre: the struggle is no longer only over the status of money or records, but over a person's immediate capacity to refuse.

Turning Phulmati into "F.M."

Phulmati's name is compressed in a file to the initials "F.M." The abbreviation is not an innocent convenience, since it accompanies attempts to erase her family relationships, work and right to independent choice. The form describes its subject as entering a "voluntary service contract." Against the abbreviated entry and the institutional language, Phulmati states: "My name is Phulmati." The return to the complete name is a grammatical and ethical recovery of identity within the scene. Yet the courage of pronouncing it must not be mistaken for the establishment of long-term safety. The chapter shows an act of resistance and a threatened life, not a fully secured future.

The Small Scene of the Withheld Thumbprint

Outside Room R07 of the hotel, Phulmati cannot read the form placed before her. An image of her deceased grandmother seems to warn her against giving her thumbprint. The magical image brings the memory of an older woman into a minor physical action in the present. Refusing or postponing the thumbprint is not a spectacular public uprising, but within the circumstances it is a decision she can still make. The narrative preserves female agency in precisely that small interruption. Its importance is enlarged by the surrounding fear. An inherited voice of warning does not by itself resolve the danger, but it sustains a brief space in which consent can be withheld.

The Upper Floor of the Hotel and the Hall Below

The threatened assault on dignity on the third floor and a conference on "women's dignity" in the hall below form the chapter's sharpest spatial irony. An audience listens to cultivated public arguments while a closed room within the same building is used for coercion. Readers are given access to both locations and can therefore perceive a contradiction unavailable to several of those attending the event. The narrative does not need a separate abstract account of institutional hypocrisy: the arrangement of floors, doors and speakers places ideal language and concealed practice in direct confrontation. The building's geography itself becomes an instrument of criticism.

The Sudden Change in Soumya's Speech

Soumya Ramanathan takes the stage with a prepared address on rehabilitation, labour protection and transparency. The coconut-leaf decorations stir another vocabulary of memory, and she argues that dignity cannot be granted as a gift from above. Her achievement, however, is not confined to eloquent speech. Upon receiving Gop's message, she leaves the microphone and moves towards Room R07. The narrative tests the truth of words through a change of location and action. A movement from platform to closed door becomes a small but decisive plot development. It distinguishes a public profession of concern from the willingness to interrupt a specific act of coercion.

The Social Ambivalence of Witnessing through a Camera

At the instruction to go live, a journalist begins recording; the door opens, and Phulmati comes out. The broadcast disrupts the perpetrators' ability to contain events within the room. Yet the presence of a camera must not be equated with safety in every circumstance. An earlier chapter showed the same medium recasting a grieving woman's narrowed eyes as a smile of gratitude. Here it may help resist control, but its ethical meaning depends on how it is used, whether the subject agrees and what context accompanies the images. The chapter therefore refuses to assign a single fixed moral role to digital recording.

Phulmati's Emergence as a First-Person Speaker

Phulmati rejects the imposed designation "trainee" and demands permission to call her family. The specificity of her demand is crucial. She does not claim to speak abstractly for every woman; she insists upon her own name and her right to restore contact with her household. This voice is unlike the elaborate speeches of experts at the conference. The person under threat becomes able to state what she needs in language that belongs to her. The critical account must preserve that ownership of the utterance

rather than absorbing her voice into somebody else's programme of rescue, publicity or moral representation.

Hulāsi's Spectral Turn in the Game

Hulāsi crosses the boundary in spectral kabaddi while calling Phulmati's name. A dead woman speaks in solidarity with a living one, creating a narrative connection between injuries suffered in distant periods. Hulāsi's insistence that her own death not be misdescribed as suicide resonates with Phulmati's insistence upon her identity and right to refuse. Nevertheless, the episodes are not identical in their circumstances. The novel builds continuity in the struggle to tell one's own story while allowing different women's experiences to retain their specificity. Ghostly solidarity is a form of collective memory, not evidence that every historical act of violence is interchangeable.

Gop's Three Columns: Fear, Payment and Protection

After Phulmati's experience, Gop creates a file separating fear, payment and protection into distinct columns. This distribution moves the investigation away from a simplistic picture of a single criminal act towards the network's different functions. Phulmati appears under fear; Batra, Raghav and Lau under payment; Hariharan under protection. A question mark remains beside Satyavrat's name. These are working classifications within a preliminary investigation, not a final legal roll of offenders. The unfinished status of the file matters. It maps possible connections and different forms of power while keeping the uncertainty surrounding particular persons visible.

The Narrative Grammar of "Consent"

The hotel's form says "voluntary," yet the story places alongside it threats involving family photographs, debt and intimidation. Satyavrat later writes that voluntariness cannot be genuine under fear. The narrative sequence matters: it first gives readers a situation of coercion and then articulates a critical proposition about consent. The argument therefore grows from the preceding scene rather than appearing only as an external slogan. Neither the printed title of a form nor the taking of a thumbprint is sufficient, within the literary situation, to demonstrate free agreement. The scene makes language itself part of the conflict over a woman's autonomy.

The Planned Counterattack against Soumya

Batuknath Hariharan orders inquiries into Phulmati's family debt, Soumya's foreign funding, a journalist's possible defamation liability and Gop's identity. The response seeks to redirect attention from the original

allegation towards the personal standing and financial dependencies of those questioning the network. This is a strategy for controlling the story that can be told publicly. At this stage, however, the retaliatory measures are narrated as plans or instructions; their every allegation and consequence is not established as fact. Maintaining that temporal distinction clarifies the intention behind the threats without imagining prosecutions or reputational outcomes not yet narrated.

Multiple Accounts in the News

Following the episode, different outlets offer different descriptions: a "dispute at an institution," an "allegation by a trainee," and, in some cases, silence. The live video has circulated, but its significance remains a matter of journalistic selection and competing language. Publication gives a previously confined person an opportunity to be heard while also exposing her account to reformulation by others. The chapter thereby returns to the central problem of representation. A witness may speak, and a recording may exist, yet the struggle over what her words and actions mean continues. Circulation is a development in the conflict, not its automatic resolution.

Phulmati's Living Voice on Ujjwal's Phone

Devika sees and hears Phulmati through the phone that remains after Ujjwal's death. One device is at once a repository of a young man's last communication and the means by which a living woman's emergence from confinement becomes visible. The screen therefore cannot have a single symbolic value. It can support exploitation, preserve testimony, contain grief and carry resistance. This range of functions complicates the earlier image of "the crocodile in the screen." What matters is not the device's essence but the surrounding relations of power, intention and use. Its capacity to bear both loss and intervention deepens the novel's account of technological modernity.

Overall Assessment: Autonomy over Name and Body

"The Market in Bodies" gives power an unusually tangible form: a closed door, a suppressed voice, a hand on a shoulder, a withheld thumbprint, a journalist's phone and Phulmati stepping outside. The simultaneous conference below and threatened confinement above constitute the chapter's strongest formal device. One limitation is the speed with which several characters articulate the moral and legal implications, potentially reducing interpretive subtlety. But Phulmati's own insistence on speaking brings the narrative beyond a general manifesto. Her specific name, family and demand to leave make the action the story of a living person rather than a symbolic instance of victimhood.

Critical Section 111 | Original Chapter 10 — Blackmail through Privacy

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

A New Plot of Theft from the Inner Life

In Chapter 10, the object of exploitation is no longer only labouring bodies or bank deposits but a person's private relationships and authority to define herself. The opening image of Hulāsi's contested death narrative in Channa Grove provides an older form of the problem: an unwanted public account of a life is not equivalent to the person telling her own story. When the narrative turns to Mrinalini Arya's relationship, preserving names becomes inseparable from protecting privacy. The chapter's ethical structure depends upon this distinction. Disclosure cannot be treated as virtuous merely because it reveals information; the question of who speaks, by choice and to whom, is equally central.

Mrinalini and Meera: The Question of a Second Name

Mrinalini Arya researches technology law and is known within her household as Meera. Her initials "M.A." in a file, formal public identity and intimate name mark different registers of a single life. Difference between these registers is not in itself wrongdoing. It becomes a source of coercion when the network attempts to weaponise one social identity against another. Meera knows the facts of her private life and makes decisions about their disclosure. A critical reading must not reduce her to a passive item in Gop's records. The plurality of her names is a feature of human social existence that makes the subsequent attempt at blackmail more invasive.

Love and Blackmail as Different Moral Matters

Meera loves a woman named Aditi. The chapter does not make that love the wrong to be explained. The abuse consists in copying private messages, travel bookings, photographs, medical consultations and receipts without consent, then threatening to circulate them to relatives, media organisations, the university and legal institutions unless testimony is withheld. The threatened disclosure draws its coercive force from anticipated social stigma. The dignity of a private relationship and the freedom to give evidence are therefore connected but distinct rights. Translation must preserve the narrative's allocation of wrongdoing: the crime under scrutiny is the theft and threatened use of personal information, not Meera's relationship with Aditi.

The Long Fear Created by a Disappearing Message

The threat arrives as a message programmed to disappear within five minutes. Its technical lifespan is brief, but the fear remains in Meera's mind and shapes her ensuing choices. The opposition between digital transience and psychological duration is the chapter's temporal device. Readers know the message may no longer be visible, yet its effect continues in the character's hesitation and thought. The episode extends the broader narrative interest in records that can be altered or erased: disappearance from a device does not mean disappearance from memory. The conflict is not simply over retaining a screenshot but over the lasting power a fleeting communication can exercise over a life.

Aditi's Reply and the Restoration of Conversation

Meera repeatedly opens and closes telephone contacts before Aditi calls her. Aditi's response offers steadiness without a grand speech or an official guarantee. She insists that the offender has no right to determine how Meera lives. The dramatic significance of this exchange is the interruption of isolation. Blackmail becomes powerful when the threatened person feels compelled to carry a secret alone; a trusted voice weakens that mechanism. The narrative does not claim that fear evaporates completely after the call. Rather, Meera gains a relationship within which a decision can be considered and expressed. Conversation restores some agency without pretending to eliminate the external danger.

Testimony on Explicit Conditions

Meera sets conditions when approaching Gop: the issue must be the attack on privacy, intimidation without consent and the criminal network, not her same-sex relationship. This does more than state a moral preference. It redirects the narrative's focalisation by allowing the witness to define the subject of the inquiry. Gop's response, that the matter concerns a structure rather than the person's private life, acknowledges a new investigative discipline. Meera refuses to let an outsider's perspective dictate what her relationship should mean. She is attempting to exercise authority not only over whether she gives evidence, but over the form and permissible scope of that evidence.

The Difference between Being a Victim and Becoming a Witness

In conversation with Soumya, Meera decides to speak as a witness rather than remain an object of pity. The shift challenges a convention in which injured people are portrayed as permanently without agency. Nevertheless, the choice to testify does not end her vulnerability. It is a social role adopted while fear and possible harm remain. The scene holds together the right to give evidence and the right to restrict indiscriminate public

exposure. Human dignity becomes an act of narrative authorship: the character speaks about what happened to her rather than permitting the opposing side to turn her personal life into the principal spectacle.

Folder Order and the Organisation of Allegations

On Meera's laptop, folders named “threat,” “account,” “chat,” “server,” “Batra,” “Hariharan” and “L.K.” open in sequence. The private threat becomes connected to material about payments and a wider network. Gop recognises a method for preventing a person from testifying, rather than a merely isolated breach of confidentiality. Yet a folder title is not a final determination of the allegations it contains. The arrangement constitutes a structured beginning for inquiry. As a narrative device, the order of the folders makes different layers of the alleged network visible to the reader one after another, without claiming that each possible connection has already been fully established.

The Narrative of Structural Shame

Meera fears that society will allow a criminal to transform her love into a weapon. Her fear does not originate in an inherent wrongness of the relationship but in family silence, anticipated accusation and the judgments of others. The narrator distinguishes this “social court” from an actual court of law. Private human attachment comes into conflict with the capacity of a watching community to impose shame. Privacy is consequently not the protection of something inherently disgraceful. It is the right to set boundaries around who may tell one's life and on what terms. This distinction is essential to the literary criticism of the episode.

Satyavrat's Private Note

On receiving a sealed communication, Satyavrat writes about witness dignity and the protection of private information. Rather than judge the relationship itself, he concentrates on the source of intimidation. This is another stage in the government's lawyer's internal ethical development. It should not, however, be described as an already implemented judicial order or witness-protection scheme. A private note signals recognition of the right issue; a functioning institutional response would require further action. The distance between moral awareness and administrative implementation remains one of the novel's persistent concerns, now expressed through the problem of confidentiality.

The Offender's Defence: Change the Subject

Batuknath and Chandrapal consider shifting attention away from the substance of Meera's testimony towards questions about her character and reputation. The manoeuvre is a form of narrative coercion. The witness

wants to describe a specific intrusion and threat; the opposing side seeks to enclose her within a different story about who she supposedly is. Since readers have encountered Gop's files and Meera's own account, they can recognise the selective nature of this proposed counter-narrative. The strategic discussion must nevertheless be distinguished from the final outcome of any hearing. The chapter depicts an attempt to control the terms of public interpretation.

Hulāsi and Meera across Historical Time

As Hulāsi crosses the spectral boundary, the night of her death at the well returns to view. She has objected to the designation of suicide. Meera likewise resists the seizure and threatened publication of the account of her own life. Both episodes concern who possesses the right to narrate a woman's experience, yet their historical circumstances are not the same. The ghostly game reveals a recurring mechanism of domination without abolishing particular differences. Its intertemporal structure asks the reader to hear two distinct voices and to recognise a common struggle over self-description. Analogy works here through a relation of power, not through literal equivalence between events.

The Limits of Publication

Meera supplies copies of the threats for appropriate legal use but does not authorise public distribution of every private detail. This condition complicates the recurring ideal of bringing truth to light. Revelation may itself reproduce humiliation when it exposes material unrelated to what justice requires. The chapter accordingly distinguishes the information needed for investigation from the personal details that ought to remain under the witness's control. Her evidence does not become public property simply because wrongdoing may have occurred. Restraint in publication is presented as an ethical act, not as concealment on behalf of the offender.

Overall Assessment: Authority over the Private Story

"Blackmail through Privacy" places witness testimony and witness confidentiality on the same side rather than treating them as opposing claims. Meera's conversation with Aditi, Soumya's support, the ordered folders and Satyavrat's note develop the problem across several forms of narration. At times the moral propositions are stated with considerable explicitness, which risks reducing the reader's interpretive work. Meera's fear, hesitation and carefully stated conditions, however, keep her from becoming merely an argumentative emblem. The fundamental event is the theft and threatened use of information. Her love is not the offence; preserving that distinction is indispensable to a faithful reading.

Critical Section 112 | Original Chapter 11 — The Black River of Money

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From a Geographical Metaphor to Financial Flows

A dark underground current seems to rise beneath Channa Grove. It is not an actual river but a visual analogue for money moving between accounts. Through the Kamala, Balan, Ganges, Indus, Mekong and Pearl rivers, the narrator brings distant financial networks into the familiar vocabulary of watery geography. The terms “flood” and “receding water” are also used as coded expressions by participants in the network. The metaphor gives economic mobility a language that villagers and readers may recognise through earlier stories of water. Yet an account transfer is not a natural river, and the condition of one watercourse does not establish the course of a financial transaction.

The Dramatic Arrival of a Second Memory Device

Ishan Dutt brings a second memory device, distinct from the one concerned with Meera's stolen private information. Its subject is the movement of money. This change in material object redirects the investigation. When the new file opens, the word “current” appears, and entries progressively connect bridge payments, medical supplies, gambling, mule accounts, digital intimidation and additional financial transactions. A small device becomes an aperture onto a geographically extensive narrative. The technique condenses many places into the act of examining one screen. Such concentration does not mean the device already contains an indisputable and exhaustive legal history of every connection that appears in the files.

Renaming through the Language of Crime

Words such as “metal,” “dust,” “route” and “prayer” appear as codes in the files. According to Ishan, ordinary or sacred expressions are being used to conceal illicit activity. The narrative draws attention to language as an active instrument of wrongdoing. A coded word does not merely describe an operation; it alters how an outsider may recognise and classify it. But the proposed meanings are offered within the investigation. They are not separately verified for every transaction in an equally detailed manner. The critical account must preserve this level of uncertainty. The power of the scene lies in the clash between apparently innocuous words and what the investigator believes those words are being made to conceal.

Chandrapal's Aesthetics of Legal Propriety

A folder called “Lakhéra Consulting” contains Batra's polished opinion papers and signatures. The outward cleanliness of legal language becomes a possible disguise for an exploitative network. On a desk are law books; inside related materials appear identity papers, students' accounts and women's private photographs. This arrangement of objects creates an ironic contrast between institutional respectability and concealed practice. The alleged operators gain power not solely through threats but through the appearance that their arrangements are lawful. The narrative's criticism is therefore directed towards the misuse of forms and words that claim legitimacy, while the precise documentary basis of each accusation still requires attention.

The Different Narrative Roles of Hariharan, Raghav and Lau

Batuknath Hariharan represents legal reputation and procedural protection; Raghav Somani is the less visible intermediary of messages and communication; Lau Kin-Hung appears as a distant centre for collecting gains. To combine them into one undifferentiated villain would erase the architecture of the network. Their modes of speech differ as well: Hariharan's public address, Raghav's disappearing messages and Lau's orders couched in percentages. These distinct narrative registers reveal power as a set of relationships rather than a list of bad individuals. The analysis must keep roles and degrees of visibility apart, even when the broader story draws them into one investigation.

The Remaining Traces of Deleted Messages

Raghav's rule is to leave no voice, paper or face, yet Ishan identifies fragments of deleted communications in the file. An intention to produce absence becomes a source of clues. The paradox renews the novel's older image of names cut from registers, this time in the digital domain. The fragments carry narrative suspense because they suggest something that the actors attempted to erase. Still, a recovered fragment is not identical to a complete original conversation. The broken form of the evidence should remain broken in criticism. Incomplete language both raises the possibility of a hidden scheme and preserves the difficulty of reconstructing its exact course.

Reconstructing the Route of Ujjwal's Money

Devika asks where the money taken from her brother went. Gop traces deposits, withdrawals, debt entries and the dispersal of payments into small accounts after the threats. Thirty-five accounts include names associated with students, rickshaw drivers, widows, unemployed people and fictitious identities. This range makes the network's social intermediaries visible.

However, the appearance of a name as an account holder does not establish that person's knowledge of a crime. Munna's earlier introduction makes precisely this distinction necessary. The reconstruction gains ethical force by showing the unequal positions of people involved in the flow, rather than automatically converting every person named in a list into an offender.

The Reasoning of Devika's Grief

After seeing the routes of the money, Devika says that her brother was "pushed" towards his end. Bereavement now finds a possible relation to a traceable pattern of transactions. The others do not respond with a single easy legal answer. An uneasy silence follows. This restraint is significant: Devika's statement carries the force of a surviving sister's protest without being made a final judicial determination of causation or responsibility. The financial lines permit a new question to be asked, but they cannot simply reverse death or resolve every uncertainty around it. The chapter allows grief to become argumentative while retaining the distinct work of investigation.

The Decision to Withhold Details of the Route

After examining a map of cross-border transfers, Soumya argues against publishing a complete operational route. Ishan has already obscured parts of the information. The scene makes publication itself a question of ethical judgment. It is important to expose exploitation, but it is not acceptable to supply reusable instructions for committing the same offences. Openness and safety need not be absolute opposites: a carefully drawn boundary can serve both. The narrative gives a reason for selectivity without turning that selectivity into the concealment of wrongdoing. The critical distinction is between informing people that the network exists and revealing operational methods that would facilitate its repetition.

Re-editing Broom's Speech

Ishan places financial entries beneath the ethical terms used in the earlier video of the overseas lecture: dignity, safety, partnership and innovation. This produces a second text on top of the first. A polished official address is set against the transactional material identified by investigators. The formal device is an act of re-editing: the meaning intended by the speaker is challenged by a parallel record of economic connections. The resulting irony is strong, but the level of substantiation for every financial attachment remains whatever the underlying narrative actually shows. An accusatory juxtaposition is a literary strategy, not a substitute for specifying how much has been independently established.

The Damp Envelope Sent to Satyavrat

An unsigned, damp envelope containing a memory device appears on Mehta's desk. Its compressed oppositions—thirty and three hundred, debt and coercion, commerce and the black river—summon the major strands of the first part of the narrative. The object transfers a problem developed across public institutions into the private space of a government lawyer's study. Receiving it becomes a test of office, reputation and personal judgment. The dampness also recalls the physical traces of water that have accompanied earlier documentary discoveries. The scene does not narrate a completed decision; it sets a material and ethical challenge before a character who has long hesitated.

Three Copies of the Evidence

Gop preserves one copy for Mehta, another for Ira abroad and a third in the hollow of the peepal in Channa Grove. This strategy brings the old tradition of keeping duplicate records into the contemporary world. Legal inquiry, an international forum for questions and local community memory are maintained as separate sites of custody, reducing dependence on a single vulnerable repository. The three copies represent different possible avenues for future action. They do not by themselves establish the authenticity of every file or guarantee a judicial result. Duplication protects opportunities for scrutiny; it cannot relieve the holders of the need to investigate and decide responsibly.

The Weariness of Collective Testimony

Burhbā and the other ghosts experience "the fatigue of testimony." The idea that bodiless figures can become exhausted is a deliberate paradox. It renders the burden of repeated injustice perceptible: the community keeps adding names, yet the list of losses continues to grow. The nightly labour of Gop, Soumya, Devika, Meera and others has a parallel in the spectral game. The structure acknowledges not just heroic persistence but the insufficiency of resistance that must constantly begin again. Collective narration is thus capable of admitting fatigue as well as hope, an important complication of the repeated injunction to remember every name.

Overall Assessment: The Countercurrents of Money and Memory

"The Black River of Money" attempts to render a sprawling financial network as a connected story. The dark current of funds and the green boat of remembrance provide the chapter's principal opposition. Its strength comes from the differing perspectives through which the material is disclosed. Its formal risk is the appearance of an excessively complete conspiracy, since many distinct transactions quickly seem to lead towards

one centre. Yet Devika's question, Meera's conditions, Soumya's caution about disclosure and Satyavrat's unresolved decision preserve human judgment within that vast pattern. The narrative remains strongest when connections are traced without pretending that every evidentiary gap has vanished.

Critical Section 113 | Original Chapter 12 — Coconut Leaves on the Dark Web

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

Evidence Protected amid Darkness

In Chapter 12, the centre of attention shifts from discovering financial movements to protecting the materials already gathered. A device kept in the hollow of the peepal unites Channa Grove's folk memory with the digital world. The ghosts adopt four cautions: preserve truth, do not turn it into a recipe for crime, safeguard names and release information according to need. These principles establish a new narrative discipline. The question is no longer only whether evidence can be found but how it should be kept and who ought to receive it. The chapter makes custody and ethical publication into actions of the story rather than treating disclosure as an automatic good.

Three Copies and Three Kinds of Risk

Ishan observes that three copies bring three dangers as well as hope. Satyavrat's office, Ira's foreign institutional setting and the hollow of the peepal are subject to different kinds of power. The legal copy faces bureaucratic or official resistance; the university copy may encounter conflicts with donor interests; the village copy relies upon physical and symbolic vigilance. Multiplication of files is not mechanical invulnerability. Each location brings a new responsibility. This difference is important for understanding the novel's geography of memory: official procedure, international scrutiny and communal guardianship cannot simply replace one another, although they may be able to support each other's work.

The Difference between “Reading” and “Accepting”

Ishan reports that the device has reached Satyavrat but warns that reading the files is not the same as accepting their implications. In the government lawyer's study, official affidavits and the new list are examined against one another. Possession of a record can open a path towards moral knowledge, yet an actual decision requires the character's independent agency. The distinction prevents a technological shortcut in the plot. Discovery of data does not automatically reform an institution or compel a witness to act. Instead, the drama moves into the uncertain interval between information being made available and responsibility being assumed by the person who must assess it.

The Narrative Force of a Plain Table

Mehta's screen displays no sensational film. There are names, dates, payments, signatures, revised copies and missing pages. The narrator presents truth in the potentially tedious form of documentary rows. This is a significant literary choice: acute suffering may be encountered not only through striking images but through painstaking comparison of apparently ordinary entries. The discrepancy between a declaration that a safety inspection was complete and the time of an earlier accident creates irony within the paperwork itself. By resisting an exclusively spectacular form of revelation, the chapter makes patient reading part of the activity of witnessing.

The Private Narrative of Shame

Satyavrat initially feels shame rather than anger. His professional competence in government service sits uneasily beside what his own conscience now recognises. This inward response distinguishes him from the figure of an unconflicted heroic lawyer. The quiet study becomes the place where an eventual public choice may originate. Shame is a stage in moral development, however, not yet a resignation, a comprehensive disclosure or a successfully executed institutional challenge. The narrative holds him at a threshold. What he has read requires interpretation and action, and his inner discomfort marks the growing difficulty of continuing as before.

Ira's Re-reading of Her Lineage

A file called “Names of Garh Narikela” places Lattar, Kalit, Nand, an image of the bridge and a passage from Broom's speech in one arrangement. Ira consequently reads her family history in a different way. The overseas-born character is not compelled by ancestry alone; inquiry and choice allow her to establish a new relation to her inheritance. The assertion that she is “not a foreigner” works as an emotional expression of connection. Criticism should nevertheless refrain from erasing real differences among birthplace, citizenship and cultural identification. The chapter's achievement is the active reinterpretation of lineage, not the claim that all institutional and geographical distinctions have disappeared.

The Narrative Risk of an Unknown Source

An unidentified sender provides Ira with a file, while a nameless envelope arrives in Satyavrat's study. Such mysterious delivery accelerates the story but raises questions about the provenance and custody of evidence. In places the narrator draws upon magical realism to permit documents to reach their intended readers. As literature, the process suggests the persistence of memories that the dead refuse to relinquish. In a plot

centrally concerned with legal proof, however, unexplained origins may weaken procedural credibility. The criticism must recognise both functions: the poetic force of documents that insist on surviving and the investigative limitation created when their route cannot be fully established.

The Ghosts' Vigil: Collective Memory in Action

Witches or spectral women arrange a night watch around the hollow of the peepal, and Loth becomes a guard rather than merely an observer. Memory takes the form of collective labour, not passive possession of an archive. Burhbā's rule that each visitor must first speak their own name becomes a folk analogue of a password. The truth of one's name is figured as a key to the light. Yet this magic ritual is not a technical description of real digital access controls. The scene instead constructs an internal conversation between traditional beliefs about recognition and contemporary language about protecting stored information.

Darkness as a Fourth Refuge

Alongside the three copies placed in identifiable locations, Ishan proposes an additional concealed copy within the "dark web." The narrative presents that environment as both a potential criminal passageway and a possible last refuge for evidence. The material would not be released immediately but held until a proper occasion. Darkness consequently acquires a context-dependent meaning. It is not everywhere identical with wrongdoing; sometimes secrecy can serve the protection of people or information. This remains a literary and ethical proposition, not a technical manual for concealing files in any specific online system. The point is why preservation and timing may matter as much as disclosure.

Confidentiality versus Protecting Offenders

Meera insists that private identifying details not be published without consent. Soumya similarly opposes distributing the network's operational methods. These limits prevent maximum publicity from becoming the narrative's unquestioned moral standard. Legal review, communal remembrance and personal dignity call for different levels of access. Truth must be communicated according to a considered purpose and the authority of its recipient. The chapter's proposal is not to suppress evidence of wrongdoing but to separate information needed for accountability from details whose publication would injure victims or assist further offending. Such differentiation makes disclosure an accountable process rather than a single dramatic revelation.

Devika's Wish to Preserve Ujjwal's Name Publicly

Devika permits Ujjwal's name to be used as part of a public warning. This does not contradict Meera's refusal to expose intimate details. In each case the narrative concerns the wishes and responsibilities of those connected with the information. Devika offers her understanding of what her dead brother would have wanted, but that interpretation must not be presented as Ujjwal's own written consent. The chapter treats the relation between private grief and public education as a difficult responsibility for surviving family members. Protecting a person's name may sometimes require speaking it openly and at other times require discretion.

Legal Procedure in Hariharan's Dream

In Hariharan's dream, a judge's chair turns into the back of a crocodile while Batra insists that "procedure will save us." The language of legal process becomes an image of magical menace. Because it is explicitly a dream, the scene renders a character's inward anxiety rather than offering independent documentary evidence of an event in court. The dream also complicates the villain's psychology: the lawyer is not portrayed as a machine immune to fear. Fear alone, however, is neither remorse nor proof of ethical redemption. A faithful account must avoid turning the supernatural experience into a moral conversion not yet narrated.

A Global Map in the Veins of a Peepal Leaf

Near the ending, the veins of a leaf seem to link the Kamala-Balan, the Ganges bridge, Delhi, Harvard, Hong Kong and Ujjwal's impoverished household. Local ecology becomes a figurative map of international financial relations. The image extends the spatial uncertainties of the earlier "village on the right bank" into a world-spanning set of connections. It does not establish that the world has become an equal, undifferentiated village. Control over money, linguistic authority and exposure to physical danger remain unequally distributed. The leaf's network represents connected histories while reminding the critic that connectedness is not sameness.

Overall Assessment: When Should the Light Be Released?

"Coconut Leaves on the Dark Web" moves the inquiry into a new ethical stage: judgment about the dissemination of evidence after its collection. The boundaries of victims' privacy, differentiated custodianship of copies and problems created by anonymous sources appear together. Ishan, Gop, Meera and Soumya form several loci of decision; no single character settles everything. A particular narratological achievement is the revised meaning of darkness. Within this fictional world it is not exclusively the realm of falsehood but can, under limited conditions, provide a temporary place of

protection. The chapter's unresolved task is to balance that protective concealment with future public accountability.

Critical Section 114 | Original Chapter 13 — The Sealed Cover

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Long-Awaited Return to the Courtroom

After the long history of adjourned dates, the story returns to the physical interior of a courtroom. Satyavrat's study holds three documents representing different moments of the narrative: a government affidavit, Gop's list and Nand's earlier petition. Bringing them together makes the movement from private conscience towards public responsibility visible. The old bridge incident acquires renewed form within legal language. Yet the return to court is not an announcement of final adjudication: it is a fresh opportunity for the voices and records excluded from the earlier proceedings to be heard. The chapter's narrative development depends on that precise difference between entering a forum and receiving a final decision.

The Old Impression of a Typewriter

Mehta types a brief note on an old typewriter rather than on a computer. The letters pressed into paper recall Nand's earlier insistence on preserving documents. His choice is not a general denunciation of modern technology; it is a sensory representation of an enduring personal commitment. Writing the sentence himself becomes a rehearsal for the public responsibility he is about to assume. The contrast between a digitally alterable line and the apparent indentation left by typewriter keys acquires an almost mythical significance of durability in the narrative. Its meaning is produced through material touch and the history of recording, not through a claim that every mark made on paper must be reliable evidence.

The Strategy of Seven Legal Doors

Hariharan raises in a single sequence objections about maintainability, limitation, standing, privacy, national security, arbitration and confidentiality. The judge describes the manoeuvre as closing seven doors. The image recasts the court, already familiar as the crocodile of interminable dates, as a procedural labyrinth. The scene brings into conflict the potential legitimacy of particular legal objections and the allegation that their collective deployment delays consideration of the underlying wrongs. It would be an oversimplification to pronounce each defence inherently baseless simply because Hariharan advances it. What

the narrative places under scrutiny is the concerted obstructive use of legal procedure and the resulting distance between testimony and a hearing on its merits.

The Government Lawyer's Change of Language

Satyavrat declares that if the state stands upon incomplete records, it stands upon untruth. The statement questions the language of the official affidavit from within the state's own representative position. He does not immediately abandon his role as a government advocate to become private counsel for the petitioners. Instead, he asks that the state's record be made complete. This rhetorical reversal is the scene's political and ethical centre. Agency consists not in fleeing one institution for another but in attempting to alter what the institution must acknowledge. The narrative gives his change force through his precise demand for a better record, while leaving the subsequent institutional response open.

The Seal as Protection and as a Grave

The judge directs that sensitive material be submitted in a sealed cover. Satyavrat pauses and argues that intimate personal details should remain protected while preliminary lists of names and questions concerning the preservation of records must remain open. This tension is among the chapter's most distinctive elements. Confidentiality may shelter a vulnerable witness, but excessive secrecy can bury testimony a second time. The story neither condemns every seal nor treats sealed procedure as automatically beneficial. Its central questions concern purpose, limits and access: which information must be protected, from whom, and at what cost to public knowledge of the underlying events? The same documentary act may conceal or defend, depending on its use.

The Bench's Limited Decision

The bench indicates that private information should remain sealed, a preliminary list of names should be available to the opposing side, relevant records should not be destroyed and appropriate agencies should be notified. These are preliminary protective directions. The actual number of deaths, the path of financial transfers and the ultimate responsibility of particular individuals remain matters for inquiry. The order therefore represents a significant procedural development, not the conclusion of the entire dispute. That distinction preserves the narrative's several kinds of time: one ruling can change the conditions of investigation without settling every historical, personal and financial question that investigation has brought to light.

A Demand for the Right to Read Names

Satyavrat asks to read the names of the dead in court. Hariharan dismisses the proposal as an emotional performance. The judge, however, allows an initial reading of actual names rather than a merely symbolic demonstration. A change occurs in the courtroom's auditory arrangement: individuals are spoken of by name instead of being compressed into a number. The event recalls the village's ceremonies of remembrance while also remaining a distinct legal occasion. Reading names does not amount to a completed investigation of the deaths. It nevertheless interrupts the state's previously indifferent silence and gives the names a place within an officially convened hearing.

A Voice Faltering at the Fifteenth Name

Mehta falters while reading the fifteenth name. The hesitation reveals a private human being inside the public advocate's professional position. His breaking voice is more than a conventional device for provoking emotion: it registers the sudden burden of experience suppressed beneath years of formal legal work. Instead of making him heroically recite an entire list without interruption, the writer allows a bodily incapacity to become visible. Gop then rises and asks permission to read the remaining names. The transfer from one voice to another turns the moment into a shared act of listening rather than the achievement of a single exemplary speaker.

Gop's Reading of “Names Only”

The judge instructs Gop to read names only, without commentary. The reduction of explanatory or rhetorical language allows each person's identity to occupy the centre of the scene. The brief silence following a name becomes a form of mourning. This is an unusual echo of the folk prologue of Chapter ০: there the village articulated names in songs; here the courtroom receives them through plain spoken recitation. The two settings have different public procedures and different kinds of authority. Their shared purpose, however, is resistance to the erasure of human presence. The scene derives its force from that measured parallel, not from making the courtroom identical with a village ritual.

Devika's Standing to Speak

Hariharan questions Gop's formal standing. Devika intervenes, invoking the presence of her brother's name in the list. Her entry brings private grief and a woman's claim to be heard into the formal legal chamber. It does not, by itself, resolve every procedural objection concerning standing or admissibility. Rather, the brief exchange places the limits of institutional definitions beside the ethical demand of a surviving relative to speak about the lost person. The narrative gains strength from the

disproportion between the shortness of her intervention and its effect on the meaning of the assembled record.

Magical Stains and the Courtroom's Material World

The fan slows, glass clouds over, water gathers beneath shoes and marks appear on the floor. These recurrent magical signs suggest an invisible presence of the dead. A cleaner might explain the moisture as a leaking pipe; the ghosts interpret the traces as stains left by names. By retaining more than one possible explanation, the text avoids making the supernatural sign into an exclusive piece of evidence. The marks represent the encounter between grief and an institution that has struggled to hear it. Their literary effectiveness lies in the coexistence of a mundane material cause and the extraordinary meanings assigned to it by different witnesses.

Ira's Distant Simultaneity

News of the reading of names in Delhi reaches Ira at Harvard, where she prepares a new question for a forthcoming ethics lecture. Parallel scenes turn the court's limited action into a fresh challenge on a distant academic platform. The institutions nevertheless perform different functions: the court deals with records and orders, while the university provides a space for public ethical discussion. The story does not grant them an identical jurisdiction or form of authority. It arranges different kinds of response simultaneously, extending the reverberations of a single courtroom event beyond its immediate location without suggesting that the event has already resolved the controversy abroad.

Emotional Achievement and the Limits of Justice

When Gop leaves the courtroom, Ishan calls the reading of names the first breach in the water burial of memory. Soumya reminds him that justice has not yet been secured. The exchange functions as the chapter's internal criticism of its own catharsis. An act of symbolic recovery can be profound without constituting the final outcome of an institutional process. Soumya's caution is especially important because it prevents the reader from mistaking the emotional force of public recognition for proof that the inquiry is complete. The two judgments occupy different registers and must be allowed to coexist.

Overall Assessment: A Cover Half Opened

The principal narrative achievement of Chapter 13 is its dramatisation of the complicated relations among confidentiality, public recitation, state representation and procedural justice. Mehta's typewriter, Hariharan's seven doors, Devika's intervention and Gop's unsteady voice translate legal abstractions into human actions. A possible critical limitation is that the

bench's ethical responsiveness appears with relative speed. Nevertheless, the restricted nature of its order and Soumya's explicit caution prevent the ending from claiming a premature, comprehensive victory. The cover is neither wholly closed nor finally removed; its partial opening defines the chapter's precise narrative condition.

Critical Section 115 | Original Chapter 14 — The Road Home

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From the Court to Home: A Reversal of Narrative Direction

After the preliminary judicial order, characters turn from Delhi and international institutional spaces towards Garh Narikel. Their return is more than a journey across geography. Documents that functioned as records in court now become objects of ancestral memory, labour's surviving traces and collective mourning in the village. The “road” of the title is thus also the route by which displaced names return to the community that can speak them. Following its enlargement onto a global stage, the narrative re-establishes the importance of a local centre. It does not deny the work of institutions; rather, it reveals that institutional documents acquire additional human meanings when brought back among those affected by them.

Wet Shoes in the Courthouse Corridor

Outside the chamber, people notice a watery smell about their shoes. Some attribute it to an air-conditioning pipe, others to seepage in the ageing building. Aruni recognises in it the imagined presence of Ganges sand, cement and the torn gamchha. The same material trace receives several explanations. The narrator does not provide a definitive solution to the mystery. Water becomes part of the family's magical sense of the river while ordinary causes in the courthouse remain possible. The scene demonstrates how inherited memory changes the perception of an apparently incidental physical sign without requiring that every observer accept the same interpretation.

The Construction of Ananya's Childhood Question

Ananya asks her father, Aruni, whether ghosts entered the courtroom. He replies that ghosts did not come—names did. She then asks whether names can walk. Ba describes names as travellers without feet. In this three-generation exchange, the child's question independently expands the central metaphor rather than merely making it easier for the reader. Aruni tries to explain what he has witnessed; Ananya tests the meaning of his words; Ba answers from within a longer oral tradition. Their voices are not interchangeable. The mobility of names becomes a shared idea through successive, differing acts of inquiry.

The Visual Time of a Railway Journey

Aruni chooses to travel by train rather than by aircraft and taxi. Railway windows, fields, a dry pond, tea at stations and darkness along the route extend the duration of the journey. Against the speed of global communications, the slowly changing landscape gives the character time to travel through his own remembered history. The journey is a sensory transition from the cool interiority of urban archives to the earth and smells of rural memory. Yet choosing a train does not in itself demonstrate the village's moral superiority. It is the narrator's selected means of slowing time and opening an interval for recollection.

Ira's Return and Embodied Belonging

Ira Aruni returns with a copy of her Harvard address and research papers. Ba places a hand upon her head, offering an intimate gesture distinct from the formal handshakes of the international auditorium. The relationship of a character born abroad to her ancestral village does not become complete instantaneously. It grows through research, questions, travel and physical recognition. Belonging is consequently not an automatic quality of blood or birthplace; the story makes it a process of personal choice and communal welcome. The contrast between forms of touch is meaningful without erasing the actual differences of place, upbringing and experience that Ira carries with her.

The Separate Place of Nishant's Financial Inquiry

Nishant arrives with indications of the layers of payment channels and a route connecting Jaipur, Gurugram, Singapore and Hong Kong, together with accounts associated with the old bridge project. He brings a specialised perspective distinct from the archival and personal testimony of other characters. Observing a condensed map of payments is not the same as legally establishing the responsibility of everyone mentioned within it. Gop reminds him that he must learn to listen to leaves as well. The scene brings numerical analysis and oral or ecological remembrance onto the same stage, where they can challenge and complement rather than simply replace one another.

The Original Smell of the Old Chest

The original file of Nand Aruni is brought out of the family's chest. Incomplete lists of the dead, questionable safety records and writing associated with thirty additional names become a tangible inheritance. What the courtroom had seen as copies and the screen had shown as scans returns as paper with its own smell, earth and the touch of family members. The scene transforms the old chest motif from “The Village on the Right Bank.” It also resists a simple equivalence between material

authenticity and legal proof. The presence of an original document does not automatically verify every allegation that the document contains; its recovery provides grounds for renewed scrutiny.

Meera's Defence of Her Own Limits

Mrinalini hands securely preserved copies of private images, messages and threats to Soumya but decides for herself how much of her personal experience will be narrated before the village. This is a continuation of the ethical position established in the blackmail chapter. Coming home does not make every personal detail the property of a sympathetic community. The village's identity as a community of listeners must be tested through its willingness to respect the boundaries of an individual speaker. A woman's self-determination here takes precedence over any unqualified rhetoric of communal unity or total disclosure. Her choice of what to withhold remains part of the story's account of legitimate testimony.

An Assembly Without a Stage

At dusk, villagers gather around courtyards, the tulsi platform and the shade of the peepal. There is no announced programme, microphone or formal dais: faces are gathered around lantern light. This unstaged assembly reverses the arrangements of the courthouse and the Harvard auditorium. Formal office and public rank have less prominence; intimate collective listening occupies the centre. Yet a village assembly is not suddenly a replacement for the court. Its function is to restore the social visibility of names and recognise grief rather than execute a judicial order. The distinction between social remembrance and legal remedy is preserved by the structure of the scene.

The Ritual of Placing Names Upon the Earth

Gop touches the earth before opening his files. He compares the document brought home to an offering made in remembrance of the dead. Institutional evidence thus acquires the meaning of a communal act of mourning. The same papers participate in different purposes: investigation, preservation and respect for the lost. Ritual recognition, however, does not remove the responsibility to maintain evidence without alteration. Indeed, the elevation of paper into a sacred object makes the duty to protect its integrity more pressing. The scene presents material documents as objects of relation without dissolving the distinct standards that must govern their future use.

Ishan's Three Bundles

Ishan carries three bundles: lists of workers, records and payment clues concerning victims of digital fraud, and indications of overseas financial

routes. Their compact physical form gives the sprawling plot a graspable set of objects. They also represent distinct classes of material and different histories of suffering. His phrase likening them to the bones of names conveys the burden of these remnants. It does not mean that all three bundles possess the same evidentiary status in law. The narrative's task is to bring their separate histories into conversation without flattening their methods of verification.

Green Light and the Reversal of an Image

In the green glow near Channa Grove, Edward Broom's prominent face recedes while a worker's palm, cracked by cement, comes to the foreground. This is a magical rearrangement of narrative priority: the labour omitted from the institutional publicity image displaces its celebrated representative. It should not be treated as a literal account of a photograph being technically altered. The visual event is instead the story's reallocation of attention. The human body that supported the celebrated infrastructure acquires the prominence denied it in the public-relations image. The scene achieves this reversal through its magical imagery, not through an already completed external investigation.

Calling Names and Those Still Absent

During the night kabaddi, Sarayu, Nagina, Ujjwal, Hulasi and many indistinct names are heard. Some cannot be written down; they form and dissolve in water. The incompleteness checks any claim that oral remembrance possesses limitless power. Collective recitation gives dignity, but some individual identities remain beyond recovery. Ba forbids the immediate plucking of leaves from the grove, a small act that links protection of names to protection of their living ecological shelter. The passage recognises communal memory's promise and its limits at the same time: hearing a name is meaningful, yet neither every name nor the whole of every life is necessarily secured.

Overall Assessment: Reconstructing the Meaning of Home

Chapter 14 defines home not merely as a stable point on a map but as the place where names return and divergent histories can be heard together. Railway travel, the chest, the three bundles, Meera's right to set limits, Ananya's question and the green glow bring the narrative back towards the village. One critical risk is that the community may appear almost too capable of healing. The earlier folk prologue, after all, included inequalities of caste and gender within village life. A disciplined reading therefore honours the possibility of collective listening without forgetting the historical barriers that may prevent some people from speaking or being heard.

Critical Section 116 | Original Chapter 15 — The Water of Names

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Title's Supreme Metaphor and the Story's Open Ending

“The Water of Names” draws the novel's long chain of splashes, rivers, crocodiles, leaves and lists into a single large circle of meaning. Names remaining visible on water form a triumphant image, yet a line remains blank in the list at the chapter's end. The writing deliberately qualifies its own victory. Judicial steps are taken and collective remembrance grows, but the danger of future erasure does not disappear. As water continues to move, so too must the work of protecting the names of people affected by violence. The metaphor has its full force only if the critic preserves that open-ended duty rather than turning a vivid ending into a declaration that every historical dispute has been resolved.

The Leaf's Arrival and the Different Nature of Evidence

A coconut leaf comes into Satyavrat's hands, prompting an assistant to ask how such an object could be filed in court. Mehta distinguishes the original life of a record from its copy. The episode returns to the tension between literary truth, communal memory and documentary procedure. The leaf carries the ethical weight of personal remembrance; ledgers, affidavits and digital copies carry different procedural functions. Making the leaf the centre of the story's moral imagination is not equivalent to granting it every form of legal recognition. The scene is significant because it allows the ethical claim of memory and the practical rules of evidence to confront one another without being collapsed into a single standard.

Several Levels of Lists Before the Court

Mehta begins with thirty names on the official list, then reads separate categories of absent workers, deaths recorded as occurring away from the workplace, forged family signatures, discrepancies in compensation, changes of name and people never recorded at all. By distinguishing these categories, the courtroom passage moves beyond an emotionally unified recitation of names to the different ways a person may be erased by an institution. Each group requires its own form of examination. The narrative's moral insistence on remembering all the affected people is powerful, but it would distort the documentary situation to merge these

partly disputed and overlapping categories into one unqualified, finally verified total.

From Ujjwal to the "Unknown Student"

The list concerning digital fraud includes Ujjwal Jha, Rohit Mandal, Shashank, Farhan, Devashish and other unnamed young people. A tragedy previously told in the relatively developed personal story of Ujjwal is now situated within a broader social pattern. Such expansion increases the narrative's scale without giving every newly mentioned individual an equally detailed biography. The reading of a person's name and the sustained construction of that person as an independent character remain different narrative operations. The larger list should not be treated as though the reader has witnessed all of the separate lives, losses and circumstances it contains. Its function is to enlarge responsibility while retaining the painful gaps in knowledge.

A Multilayered Financial Map Enters the Courtroom

Nishant's affidavit, Ira's Harvard-related materials and accounts connecting Edward Broom's group with pandemic procurement, consultancy fees, an alleged weapons-related layer and payments reaching Lau Kin-Hung are brought into a single proceeding. Hariharan raises questions of relevance, proof and overseas jurisdiction. The court thereby becomes not simply a forum for moral speeches but a place where admissibility, access and the weight of different records remain contested. The writer does not portray the bench as having pronounced every connection conclusively established. The juxtaposition produces an expanding network narrative whose documentary and jurisdictional links must still withstand examination.

The Structure of Mehta's Seven Demands

Speaking for the state, Mehta asks for renewed verification of the dead, protection of victims of digital fraud, safeguards for privacy, inquiry into foreign financial connections, examination of legal professionals' roles, action concerning destroyed records and measures to prevent further prolonged delay. These seven demands translate several formerly separate lines of suffering into an articulated programme for public action. Ethics takes the form of requests to institutions rather than remaining exclusively a matter of feeling. Yet a request made by counsel and an order actually issued by the court are separate stages. The chapter's structure gains precision by showing what is sought before specifying what is granted.

The State Advocate's Position Within the Institution

Hariharan accuses Mehta of behaving like counsel for the petitioners. Mehta responds that the lives of citizens must be central to the state's duty. This is the public expression of a long interior conflict: shame in Chapter 12, the first move to correct the record in Chapter 13 and a firmer submission in the present hearing form a coherent sequence. Yet Mehta does not complete the draft resignation that appears later. He elects to continue the struggle from within his institution. This detail matters because it prevents his development from becoming the easy tragedy of an isolated, saintly renunciation. His agency is expressed in attempting to change an institution's practice while still occupying a contested public role.

The Next Date, Seven Days Away

The bench directs steps including a special investigation, an independent audit, protection of victims, testimony safeguarded for privacy, reference of conduct questions concerning relevant officials, restrictions affecting accounts and permission to seek overseas records. The next hearing is set for seven days later. To say that the “crocodile of court dates” has grown smaller is an apt image for the shortening of delay. These directions constitute a substantive procedural advance, not a final conviction or complete compensation. Soumya's remark that this is an order, not a final judgment, supplies the episode's decisive correction to any temptation to proclaim the dispute settled.

Fear Among the Accused and Consequences Not Yet Completed

Batra's lost signal and attempt to escape his own name, the strange rearrangement of papers in Hariharan's library and the appearance of a coconut leaf on Lau's screen create magical scenes of mounting anxiety among the accused or suspected participants. Their psychological equilibrium is disturbed by the new pressure of investigation and collective memory. Such visionary retaliation is not identical with the legal dissolution of a worldwide network. The sequence depicts fear, threat and symbolic exposure; it does not narrate definitive sentences for every individual involved. Its literary purpose is to give visible form to the reach of remembered names while keeping formal outcomes distinct from the supernatural response.

Munna's Position: An Account That Was Used

In the final list, Munna Paswan is described as the holder of an account used by others rather than being labelled a convicted criminal. This is an especially important distinction in the novel's treatment of the financial network. Chapter 8 established that Munna did not fully understand the

purpose for which his account was sought. The later investigation shows that the account became an important channel, but ignorance, economic necessity, deliberate conduct and the extent of involvement still require separate examination. The popular moral list does not erase those differences. Nor does the presence of a name in an investigative chain automatically confer a settled criminal identity upon its bearer.

Meera's Self-Determined Name

The final page includes Mrinalini by the name and identity she accepts, not through personal material taken from her by those who threatened her. The privacy-blackmail storyline reaches an important ethical turning point. A person may be honoured as a witness without having her intimate life exposed a second time. The longstanding collective demand to preserve names is revised by individual consent. Without such a revision, the act of remembrance could itself become coercive, reproducing the very appropriation of the individual's voice that the novel opposes. The scene grants dignity to the witness's decision over both what may be said and what must remain protected.

The Partial Return of Ishan's Shadow

A faint shadow returns near the feet of Ishan, who remains officially classified as dead. He says that he is not wholly free and that many files still need safeguarding. This limited return is crucial to the chapter's magical-realist closure. The fragment of a shadow signifies partial recovery of identity, not the complete end of his condition. His reassurance that he is no longer alone registers the achievement of shared labour. Yet the tasks before him and the uncertainty about his status persist. The text therefore refuses to convert an evocative restoration of his shadow into an unqualified declaration of liberation.

The Blank Line and the Narrator's Suspension of Closure

Ba gives Ananya a page whose final line is empty. It has been reserved for an as-yet-forgotten or erased person's name. This is a direct moment of self-reference: a story may end, but the register need not. Aruni begins to write that the story is finished, crosses the claim out and returns to the opening language of kabaddi. A circular structure comes into view. The return is not mere repetition, however, because remembering has now become a consciously shared practice. The finished book and the open future of communal memory can therefore occupy the same moment without being logically identical.

Overall Assessment: Responsibility Rather Than Finality

Chapter 15 joins a judicial order, the institutional self-questioning of Satyavrat, many voiced acts of remembrance, anxiety among powerful opponents and a child's future participation. One artistic risk lies in the rapid, nearly simultaneous turn towards justice across the court, university, financial world and ghostly community. The novel's symbols sometimes make change appear unusually swift. Nevertheless, the unfinished proceedings, an incomplete resignation, Ishan's partial shadow and the final blank line decisively limit the victory they accompany. Names remaining written on water are a magical pledge. Their continued preservation is an ongoing human responsibility, not a result guaranteed by the image alone.

Inter-Sectional Conclusion: Part I, Chapters 8–15

Across Chapters 8 to 15, exploitation proceeds through mobile-game debt, fake arrest threats, control over women's bodies, blackmail using intimate information, cross-border financial movements, safeguarded copies, sealed judicial materials and the communal recital of names. Channa Grove's recurring games maintain a shared language of memory throughout these eight chapters. Yet Bisesar, Ujjwal, Phulmati, Mrinalini, Munna, Gop, Satyavrat, Devika and Ishan are not participants in a single homogeneous moral category. Some are dead victims; others are living witnesses, incompletely informed account-holders, investigators or dissenting voices within institutions. The purpose of chapter-by-chapter analysis is to preserve these differences under the pressure of the novel's overarching imagery. Its extraordinary expansion of memory must be assessed together with occasional overly explicit moral exposition and the improbably swift synchrony of some hopeful changes.

Critical Section 117 | Original Chapter 16 — The Court of Channa Grove

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

A Second, Supernatural Counterpart to the Court

Immediately after the order issued in Delhi, a different court assembles in Channa Grove, where silenced voices are accorded the authority ordinarily associated with judges. The transition is a major generic leap. The city court operates through evidence, jurisdiction and orders; the grove receives testimony through wind, leaves, water, shadows and names. The creative achievement lies in placing both courts within the same fictional universe while leaving their kinds of authority distinct. Punishment in the grove belongs to a magical ethical order. It is not a sentence pronounced by a legal court, nor proof that statutory questions about guilt have already been settled.

Opening Silence and the Circulation of News

The village dogs and cats become silent, mobile screens flicker by themselves and lanterns burn without oil. News of the Delhi hearing arrives as names glimmering in a water-filled vessel. This supernatural mode of communication stands beside the mobile phone as an imaginative counterpart to instantaneous news. A political and legal report becomes a tremor in the community's moral environment. The opening itself warns the reader that the governing rules of the night's scenes will differ from those of ordinary daily life. Its sensory abnormality is not incidental decoration but the means by which the narrative announces its changed level of representation.

The Suspension of the Game and the Circle of Justice

Kabaddi is not played that night. Ghosts, spirits, rakshasas, Loth, Pānidubbi and the peepal Brahma form a circular assembly. No single elevated chair presides over the others; voices ordinarily excluded from a hearing become collectively decisive. The competitive geometry of the playing field changes into the circle of testimony. This is not a perfectly neutral tribunal, however. It exists within a tradition already committed to the dead and to preserving names. The narrative must be understood as constructing a particular ethical solidarity, not as reproducing every procedural feature of a detached, adversarial legal hearing.

Loth Changes from Spectator to Witness

Loth, condemned to watch without intervening, receives a place in the circle. The moment gives the right to speak to one whose earlier role was defined by observation and silence. This minor character development shows power being redistributed within the grove. The company of spirits is not an unchanging assemblage of symbols: its members can acquire new functions. Loth's partly exposed body also resonates with the cement dust and injured bodies of labourers. Their common appearance brings into focus a history of bodily neglect without claiming that their distinct experiences are literally one and the same.

The Arrangement of Four Calls

Wind summons the workers lost in water; peepal leaves call victims of the screen; the hair of Pānidubbi brings those deprived of bodily security or privacy; and the lantern flame calls people harmed by the trade in breath. Each summons introduces a particular strand of the preceding chapters through a different sensory medium. The resulting assembly is carefully organised rather than merely being a crowd of undifferentiated victims. The chapter's dramaturgy draws a wide field of suffering into one space while assigning each experience an entrance that recalls its earlier narrative setting. Saying only that “all the victims arrive” would lose the precision of this organisation.

The Ambiguities of Sarayu's Body and Name

Sarayu speaks in the first person about falling at the bridge works, being left without a rope and having her name removed afterwards. The cement marks upon her palms become miniature bridge piers in a magical image. Yet later documentary passages do not present her family history or the record of her identity in wholly consistent terms. An earlier episode described a woman working under her deceased husband's name. Criticism should not silently combine all these statements into a newly invented, seamless biography. The emotional authority of Sarayu's supernatural testimony is considerable, but continuity in the underlying narrative remains a question requiring attention.

The Contradiction in Ujjwal's Testimony

Ujjwal recounts the succession of initial winnings, debt, false police threats and shame within his family. But in the grove he describes being found hanging from a fan, whereas Chapter 8 had placed his slippers beside the Balan and described his body being recovered from the water the following morning. These accounts cannot simply be treated as identical eyewitness descriptions of one event. The book does not conclusively say whether the discrepancy should be understood as a poetic disturbance of a

ghost's testimony or as an inconsistency in the narrated facts. A source-faithful criticism must preserve the conflict rather than invent a reconciliation.

Meera's Freedom to Remain Silent

Meera does not reveal the intimate details of her relationship. She speaks only against the use of private information as a weapon. Even in the supernatural community hearing, the victim is not obliged to place her entire personal life before the collective. This reaffirms the conditions she set in Chapter 10. Hulasi's presence behind her represents the support of remembered women, but the authority of Meera's character resides as much in the limit of her silence as in the words she shares. The scene modifies the apparently unlimited demand to speak and record every name by acknowledging a person's right to define the boundaries of testimony.

The Masked Elder and the Denial of Breath

An elder marked by the pandemic repeats the vocabulary of bills, codes and payments in place of accessible medical aid. The compressed parallels lament a system in which documents and charges substitute for the things human beings actually need. The elderly figure is not furnished with an extensive individual biography; he partly represents a larger community of suffering. Even within that limitation, his sensory experience of breath returns the chapter from abstract finance to the body's immediate need. The grove's court thereby gathers a form of loss that cannot be reduced to either river drowning or digital fraud.

Calling the Shadows Rather Than the Bodies of Offenders

Batuknath, Chandrapal, Raghav, Lau and Broom do not appear bodily. Instead, files, screens, erased messages, percentages and the shadow of a podium represent them. These transformations embody the different techniques through which their authority is exercised: procedure, the screen, deletion, profit and the public lecture. Rather than merging them into a single monster, the chapter gives each a distinct institutional face. Yet the presence of symbolic shadows does not fulfil the formal requirement to hear an opposing party in an actual court. The literary form of accusation and the legal conditions of a fair trial remain different matters.

The Nature of Punishment Founded on Memory

The grove's punishments are not cells or physical confinement. They involve a lifelong search for erased names, sleepless hearings that never conclude, mirrors filled with Ujjwal's face, coughing during hollow ethical speeches and the exposure of private greed as a visible shadow. This is a

punishment of compelled remembrance. The wrongdoers are made to experience repeatedly the human identities that their practices attempted to erase. Its significance is ethical and imaginative. It must not be presented as a formal prison sentence or as objective supernatural evidence establishing a crime under the law. The structure of punishment turns memory itself into the court's principal power.

Sarayu's Basket and Ujjwal's Phone

After the judgment, Sarayu sets down her basket. Ujjwal offers his phone towards Devika, but she chooses to remember her brother by name instead of taking the object. The contrast shifts the meanings of familiar material signs. A basket is still the weight of labour; the phone is still marked by digital fear. The spoken name allows a person to be present in memory without being confined to the object associated with harm. Blue light turning into an earthen lamp creates a magical scene of relief. It does not reverse the deaths or certify that the material conditions producing them have disappeared.

Ba's Instruction: Work, Not Consolation Alone

At the end of the night, Ba asks that practical duties be assigned. The grove's court issues no stamped order or printable judicial decree. Its ethical outcome must be translated into what living people do the following day. This transition prevents the episode from remaining a self-sufficient supernatural spectacle. The meaning of the ghosts' hearing will depend on education, recordkeeping, protection and labour undertaken beyond the grove. A literary victory expressed only through the performance of grief would be narrower; Ba directs it towards the harder forms of continued social action.

Critical Conclusion on the Chapter

"The Court of Channa Grove" stages a many-voiced magical-realist hearing in which the old trees, rivers, screens, exploitation of bodies, pandemic losses and global finance become audible within one circle. The dramatic inclusion is a major accomplishment. At the same time, the conflicting versions of particular deaths, unstable identities and the shared vocabulary of supernatural and statutory judgment demand close attention. The completion announced here belongs to one cycle of ritual listening. It is not the end of the entire novel or the conclusion of justice in the world outside the grove. The value of the imagined court is inseparable from these limits.

Critical Section 118 | Original Chapter 17 — The Grief of Victory

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Two Levels of "Victory"

Batuknath's "victory" is presented as a triumph of procedural prestige supported by public celebration and the media. At the same time, Channa Grove's ethical judgment plants grief within his experience of winning. There is an unresolved difficulty between the favourable record-preservation order in Chapter 15 and Chapter 17's announcement that Batuknath has won: the relationship between these procedural stages or narrative times is not fully explained. Criticism should not silently convert the latter phrase into a final judgment issued by the government court. The subject of the chapter is above all the failure of Batuknath's own feeling of victory; it is not a comprehensive procedural history of how every claim and appeal was decided.

Water Beneath the Pillow: The Materiality of Private Fear

Batuknath has taps, the roof and his servants inspected, but his pillow remains mysteriously damp. He tries to dismiss Channa Grove's court as a dream, only to encounter the stubborn material sign beside his head. Water has travelled into the most protected interior of his urban home. Its presence is experienced as more than an ordinary leaking pipe; its narrative function is to bring collective remembrance into the private place where the lawyer expects to remain secure. The intrusion does not itself constitute a legal finding. Rather, the story gives fear a physical texture and suggests that an individual cannot wholly exclude the consequences of histories he has helped suppress.

The Clash of Sounds at the Felicitation Ceremony

In the bar association hall, garlands, shawls, photographs and applause surround Batuknath, but the microphone seems to utter the word "date." Outside his consciousness, the audience hears the discourse of professional success; within him, repeated judicial adjournments and the degradation of waiting return as a haunting sound. The scene employs focalisation through an antagonist. The reader has access to Batuknath's fear, whereas the ordinary listeners need not experience that sound in the same way. Unequal access to perception gives the celebration its irony: the social signs of professional prestige and the inward memory of injustice are superimposed without becoming identical public facts.

The Irony of the Missing Opponent

Batuknath's associates search the courtroom benches, tea stalls and corridors but cannot find Gop, Soumya, Devika, Meera or Aruni. The tea seller says simply that they have gone to work. This ordinary answer has an unexpected significance. Those whom the legal process kept waiting as a defeated or dependent side have begun carrying out independent tasks. Batuknath's power rested in part upon his opponents' need to return repeatedly to the institution's schedule. When their energies move elsewhere, the apparent victory becomes hollow. The scene does not establish that the case was withdrawn; it changes the locus of narrative initiative from the courtroom corridor to the community's own undertakings.

A Child's Slow Writing of "Sarayu"

In the village, Ananya twice misforms the initial letter while trying to write the name "Sarayu." Ba does not seize the child's hand to produce perfect lettering at once, allowing the word to take shape at the child's own pace. The novel's very large struggle over remembrance is condensed into a small bodily exercise. Writing a name is not an instantaneous miracle but a practice involving hesitation, error and renewed effort. Beside magical leaves and spectral assemblies, the movement of a child's fingers gives the project of memory a practical scale. Its achievement is modest yet significant precisely because it does not claim to rectify an entire history in a single stroke.

The Defeat of the Counter-Campaign

Chandrapal orders new applications, advertisements in local languages, bonuses and devices for restoring confidence in the network. Meanwhile Devika's conversations and Nishant's pamphlets spread caution in the village. The opposing sides compete over communication, trust and the time needed to influence people's decisions. The story suggests that the criminal promotion is losing effectiveness, presenting some social consequence of collective education. It does not supply a complete audited count of cancelled accounts or people saved from fraud. Narrative indications of reduced influence should therefore not be recast as exact survey findings. The struggle remains one between deliberately manufactured confidence and knowledge gained through shared experience.

Practical Teaching at the Ghat

At the pond steps, Devika advises people threatened with fraudulent digital arrest to steady themselves, call someone trustworthy and avoid remaining alone with the intimidating voice. When an elder asks whether she studied

law, she recalls her brother's death. The episode shows personal experience seeking public authority as a basis for warning others. It does not treat suffering as automatic mastery of every technical or legal issue. Devika contributes what she has lived; Nishant adds knowledge of payments and Meera brings a separate understanding of privacy. The distribution of different competences makes the teaching collective rather than presenting one survivor as an omniscient expert.

The Women's Circle as a Form of Community

Meera and Soumya sit with women in a circle without a formal platform. They discuss fear, intimate relationships, photographs and the likely responses of families. One young woman asks what will happen if her family blames her; Meera promises that the others will accompany her home. The group's strength lies less in an institutional declaration than in concrete willingness to remain present with someone facing humiliation. Opposed to Batuknath's procedural pressure, this quiet support alters the terms of everyday relationships. The scene makes solidarity visible as an offered action, while leaving open the longer difficulties of sustaining protection beyond an immediate meeting.

Ira's Movement from Questioning to Archiving

At Harvard, Ira sets aside a draft of another public question and begins work on a page for the "Garh Narikel Names Archive." Rather than concentrating solely on challenging a celebrated speaker, she attempts to build a durable record of overlooked lives. This is a shift in narrative action, not an admission of defeat. Once built, such a digital archive would still have to address consent, correction, access and verification. The chapter establishes the beginning of the effort, not a fully working and ethically complete repository. Ira's change of emphasis illustrates how a critique performed in public can develop into the less spectacular but more sustained labour of preservation.

Only "Sarayu" in Broom's Inbox

An email reaches Broom's office containing one name, "Sarayu," and an empty space, without a list of formal accusations. He tries to delete it, but the name reappears. The supernatural recurrence places a single human absence before an apparatus prepared to answer public allegations through polished statements. An accusation can be disputed within a rehearsed exchange; the simple insistence that an overlooked person existed resists such effortless rhetorical disposal. The restrained image carries considerable dramatic force. Yet the reappearing name is a magical sign of moral pressure, not a substitute for an externally verified documentary trail.

Satyavrat's Departmental Tension

Satyavrat faces an accusation of excessive ethical zeal. He does not immediately return to court with a dramatic announcement; he begins the more patient process of writing a letter. The story adds an administrative line of dissent alongside the judicial hearing. Mehta has not resigned his position: he is trying to preserve self-respect and professional responsibility within institutional limits. His slow internal time contrasts both with Batuknath's sudden fear and with the village's rapidly expanding activities. That divergence of pace is important. The novel presents several modes of action, not one universal timetable of moral change.

The Narrative Design of Grief Within Victory

The point is not that every legal victory must be false. Rather, a particular character's success through burdensome procedure loses meaning when the people he has opposed no longer organise their lives around waiting for his decisions. Applause is set against emptiness; official paper against a child's forming letters; a microphone speech against the pond-side class. Such visual and auditory contrasts give the critique force beyond abstract political argument. Nevertheless, the precise technical sense of Batuknath's legal "victory" remains obscure in relation to earlier orders, a limitation that responsible criticism should register rather than conceal.

Overall Assessment

"The Grief of Victory" rewrites the meaning of defeat from the apparent victor's point of view. Batuknath is troubled less by an immediately visible sentence of punishment than by the recognition that those injured by his procedures have stopped waiting for him. Ananya's "Sarayu," Devika's teaching by the pond, Meera's women's circle and Ira's archival work offer different forms of the collective response. The chapter's achievement lies in translating ethical opposition into scenes of ordinary labour. Its unresolved difficulty is the precise procedural meaning of the declared victory. The tension between the two must remain visible in the critical account.

Critical Section 119 | Original Chapter 18 — The Empty Court

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

Emptiness as an Extraordinary Narrative Centre

The opening presents the familiar courthouse: stairs, metal detectors, black coats, stale biscuits at the tea stall and the movement of daily business. Yet Batuknath feels that the building is empty because the particular community of injured people is absent. A contrast emerges between physical occupation and ethical emptiness. The meaning of the court is measured not by its number of visitors but by whether the people whose grievances supply its most urgent questions can be heard. The institution continues to function while its central moral subject has moved into another sphere of action. That mismatch gives the title its particular narrative precision.

Leaving the Court Versus Ending the Case

Devika, Aruni, Gop, Soumya and Meera choose writing down names and educating others in the village over continuous attendance in the courthouse waiting room. This act of narrative withdrawal must not be mistaken for formally abandoning the lawsuit, losing appeal rights or cancelling earlier orders. The novel depicts a change in social priorities. The court's legal timetable continues, but the community develops an independent rhythm of activity. Their practical refusal to remain trapped in waiting gives the title's emptiness a social meaning without erasing the ongoing relevance of judicial remedies.

Mehta's Voice and Hariharan's Objection

Inside the courtroom, Mehta speaks of the importance of reading the names of those who died. Batuknath objects that the court is not a venue for poetry. Mehta's response questions the limits of legal language. Poetry and law are presented not simply as rival genres but as different ways of making suffering publicly audible. A practical difficulty persists, however: the formal admissibility of evidence cannot automatically be equated with the cultural truth of a name spoken in remembrance. The exchange matters because it tests what a courtroom can hear without claiming that public recitation abolishes procedural distinctions.

A Break in the Familiar Rhythm of Adjournment

The judge moves towards a familiar adjournment, but the question of names now interrupts the usual ritual of postponement. The “empty” court does not mean that proceedings have literally ceased or that the building has been vacated. The emptiness lies in the interval created when the people who previously depended upon the institution assert another way of using their time. Readers who have encountered the “crocodile of court dates” can recognise a new significance in this pause. The old repetitive rhythm is no longer the only structure organising the community's lives.

The Unnamed Beginning of a Women's Circle

Meera and Soumya do not register a new association under an official title. They simply invite young women to sit together. One speaks of threatened photographs, another of love letters, a third of intimidation through the prospect of sending private material home. The circle comes into being through conversation rather than a banner or formal constitution. The narrative values the immediate trust created by such a gathering while leaving a practical question unanswered: can informal solidarity alone provide the resources and sustained assistance needed over time? Its scene of beginning should not be mistaken for an already fully established institution.

Society's First Reply: Move the Burden of Shame

Meera states that shame belongs to the person committing the violation, not to the victim. The statement changes who is permitted to define the event. Earlier, the blackmailer had sought to impose a story about the victim's intimate life; the women's gathering now rejects that imposed account. Hulasi's unseen presence connects past humiliations of women to present courage. Repeating the principle, however, does not establish that every family has revised its attitudes. The story portrays the beginning of a new social response, not the immediate elimination of the pressures that made the threats effective.

Ira's Plan for a “House of Memory”

Abroad, Ira imagines a carefully prepared register of names, villages, deaths or disappearances, and details to be included with family consent. She calls it a “house of memory,” not a website for accusations. The choice of words attempts to separate preservation from a public catalogue of denunciations. At this stage the project remains a plan. It would exceed the text to claim that an online portal has been completely developed, its consent mechanisms tested or every entry verified. The planned archive gives the community another possible form for memory while raising the obligations that any such system would have to meet.

Nishant's Inquiry Without Theft

Nishant has opportunities to observe patterns of payments connected with his employer. Rather than steal confidential internal material for unrestricted publication, he records and examines the names of suspicious points in the payment map. The distinction complicates his character. Financial knowledge can be used for inquiry without automatically authorising unlawful access to private data. This relatively constrained scene differs from the magical image of evidence secured in darkness in an earlier chapter. The narrative here depicts the effort to act through more limited and potentially lawful means, preserving the difference between a suspicion responsibly noted and a claim conclusively proved.

The Bar Council's Revised Proposal

When a proposal condemns “unauthorised” records of names, a young lawyer asks who has the right to preserve the names of the dead. Batuknath changes the proposed wording to “false records of names,” opening the further question of who can determine falsity. The dialogue reveals more than one position inside the legal profession. Not every member of the council agrees unquestioningly with Batuknath. The young lawyer's eventual silence also exposes the hierarchy through which institutional dissent can be contained. The scene prevents the criticism of the profession from becoming a completely uniform portrait while showing how a seemingly minor word may control a wider debate.

Chandrapal's Profit-Driven Fear

Chandrapal describes education, questions about accounts, ending intimidating phone calls and mutual assistance as economic risks to the network. His concern centres upon declining customers and reduced profit rather than upon the moral legitimacy of the practices involved. The narrator sets the network's commercial logic directly against the village's growing awareness. Yet the character's general reference to losing customers does not supply audited figures demonstrating precisely how many transactions were prevented. His language registers fear of a change in behaviour; the full measurable extent of that change is not presented. The difference between a character's commercial anxiety and verified quantitative results remains important.

The Children's New Rule for Kabaddi

In Channa Grove, a child who is caught in kabaddi must repeat an erased person's name rather than simply be declared out. The game's established structure of victory and defeat becomes an exercise in shared remembering. The promise to attend to names first passes into the routines of childhood education. Ghosts watch the game from behind, but living

participants now carry out the activity themselves. The scene marks the movement of moral practice beyond dependence upon a miraculous intervention by the dead. Repetition, play and learning are made part of the practical machinery through which memory might continue.

The Cleaner: An Unexpected Beginning of Civic Recording

A cleaner approaches the empty bench to wipe away a name written in chalk and remembers his own missing father, whose departure had been described in official papers as leaving work. He writes his father's name in the dust. This is one of the chapter's most effective incidents because an otherwise anonymous employee suddenly assumes the role of author and witness. The history of labouring people is no longer recorded exclusively by a celebrated investigator or a central protagonist. A person associated with subordinate, easily overlooked work writes from within his own experience. The act is small, but it opens the register of memory to someone whom the institutional order had given little narrative authority.

A New Meaning for "Empty"

The court appears vacant to Batuknath. After the cleaner writes his father's name, the bench seems occupied by the invisible presence of those who had never been admitted. Emptiness is reinterpreted as a space burdened by suppressed history. The magical-realist image gives an apparently vacant seat an ethical and historical weight. It does not establish that formal judicial procedures have actually ceased. Rather, the same physical space bears two opposed meanings: for the lawyer, a loss of the opponents upon whom his authority depended; for the reader, a gathering of unacknowledged lives that the institution has failed to see.

Overall Critical Assessment

"The Empty Court" joins the image of institutional vacancy to the emergence of an active civil community. The women's circle, the young lawyer's question, a projected overseas house of memory, children's kabaddi and the cleaner's personal act of writing belong to different social levels and cannot be reduced to one programme. The strongest character-centred moment is the cleaner writing his father's name while at work. A creative limitation is the occasional tendency to generalise the inadequacies of the court, though the continuing presence of Satyavrat and the young lawyer preserves internal distinctions within the institution. The chapter's emptiness is ultimately a question about who is allowed to occupy the public record.

Critical Section 120 | Original Chapter 19 — The Record of Names

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From Temporary Judicial Memory to Durable Inscription

When the supernatural court of the grove disperses, a practical question remains: how can the names heard during the night survive in daylight? Ba opens the old chest and brings out Nand's unfinished petition. She insists that names cherished in the heart must also be written elsewhere if they are to remain secure. The story thereby questions any easy belief in the immortality of abstract folk memory. Rather than leaving testimony entirely to ghosts, it begins establishing a material archive. The movement is not from false belief to modern truth but from an extraordinary communal hearing to the ordinary labour of preservation, where papers, names and human participation must sustain what the nocturnal assembly has heard.

A Chair of Roots and Paper Made of Leaves

The seat used by the preceding night's court was no ordinary wooden chair: it was formed from the tree's raised roots. Drops of dew, branches and leaves now become repositories of names. The familiar equipment of a courtroom—chair, paper and register—is reimagined through the living cycle of nature. One reading treats these objects as a system of signs, while another accepts their transformation as an actual magical event within the fictional world. The two interpretations are not mutually destructive. Their coexistence gives the scene its density: an archive does not merely resemble a tree, and the tree is not reduced to a decorative emblem of record-keeping.

Evidence Brought by Sarayu's Granddaughter

Sarayu's granddaughter arrives carrying a piece of bangle and a faded photograph. These surviving things retain an unofficial trace of her grandmother's presence, outside the authority of formal registers. The episode sets family remembrance against documentary absence. Yet Sarayu's earlier accounts—her death, the wages drawn in her husband's name, and the family identification supplied here—are not automatically consistent. They require careful comparison. Criticism cannot choose one version as infallible and construct a newly harmonised biography that the source does not provide. The granddaughter's testimony is narratively

consequential precisely because it makes a vulnerable life audible while leaving questions of identification and continuity open.

Writing the First Name on a Leaf Instead of Metal

Ira offers a durable metal plate brought from abroad, but Ba asks that the first name be written on a leaf. This sequence is not a rejection of technology. It is an act through which the local community determines the first meaning of its own archive. The leaf provides an entrance through familiar belief and practice; metal may subsequently serve longer preservation. Biological material and durable inscription can therefore become successive, cooperative media rather than opposing principles. The order matters: the community must first recognise the person whose name is to be kept, before permanence can be invoked as a merely technical solution to forgetting.

The Local Chemistry of Ink

Devika cleans the leaves; Meera prepares ink from soot, kajal, turmeric and Ganges water. The materials carry associations with domestic labour, bodily adornment, ritual and the river. Writing a name becomes a collective action involving household skills and social memories, not simply a laboratory operation. The novel turns its regional vocabulary of things into a meditation on documentary creation. Nevertheless, no scientific test of the ink's long-term stability is narrated. Its cultural meaning and the practical reliability of the resulting inscription are distinct questions, both relevant to the future of the proposed record.

The First Utterance of “Sarayu Devi”

Aruni writes the first name on a leaf: Sarayu Devi. A faint laugh is heard in the grove. That uncanny response may represent the community's acceptance, but the grounds for identifying the person remain the granddaughter's oral account and the objects she has brought. The writer of the name is important, yet the right to name this first subject begins with a bereaved family that remembers her. Thus the birth of the communal register rests not upon a spectacular supernatural revelation but upon the respect accorded to particular grief. The magical response gives emotional resonance to the ceremony without superseding the need to assess evidence.

Kanhaiya Paswan's Posthumous Signature

Kanhaiya's grandson brings an iron nail. The narrative says that Kanhaiya fell while working on a bridge pier, although signatures continued to appear in the official register after his death. This posthumous signature is a concrete indication of documentary irregularity. The nail, an ordinary

remnant of the site, also recalls the bodily danger of construction. Recording a name requires an encounter between an object, a relative's memory and the documents that purport to describe a worker. The apparent signature cannot simply be treated as the dead man's own act; its discrepancy points towards inquiry, while the surviving material makes the wrong intelligible as a human event.

The Rule of the Name Used at Home

A disagreement arises over forms of address such as Phulo and Phulwa. Ba establishes the rule that the name by which someone is called at home should be written down. This is more than orthographic tidying: it concerns who possesses the authority to identify a person. The standard form in a government record and the intimate form preserved by relatives serve different purposes. For a community memorial, retaining the name in living use carries dignity. For research, recording that form alongside official variants, alternative spellings and their sources would protect accuracy. The chapter draws its strength from asserting household speech without resolving every problem of documentary matching.

Fifty Names by Noon

By midday, fifty names have been written on leaves. The stated interval matters. In contrast to the single magical night of judgment, inscription requires materials, time, the comparison of testimony and the gradual arrival of people. Fifty is a measure of this day's progress, not a new final total for all the dead. It cannot simply replace either the official thirty or the contested three hundred discussed earlier. Recognising the different numerical functions preserves the novel's argument about the difficulty of counting people without turning each newly stated number into an unquestionable census.

The Community's Diverse Threads of Memory

The record includes names such as Mansur Ali, Phulo Mandal, Ganeshi Sada, Phulbasiya Khatoon, Bisesar Sah, Jagdish Yadav and Jhingur Mahato. Their variety extends the social horizon of the memorial. Some entries lack a father's name, others a husband's name; sometimes a neighbourhood is all that remains. Rather than discarding incomplete entries as defects, the archive must indicate what each recollection does and does not establish. People from different castes, classes and families enter the list, but the fact of appearing on one page does not by itself produce substantive equality among them. Inclusive representation and social transformation remain distinct achievements.

The Expanding Perimeter of the Archive

The grove's participants begin to imagine a record encompassing not only those lost in earlier water burials but victims of screen-based exploitation, violence against women, failures of medical care and other forms of erasure. The crocodile metaphor develops into a public ethic of remembrance. Such expansion increases the range of persons deserving concern, yet it also risks flattening different harms into a single explanation. If the archive is to support inquiry, the categories must retain their separate causes and evidentiary requirements. Its moral breadth cannot be secured by abolishing distinctions essential to each particular history.

Ira and the Copy Sent Abroad

Ira wishes to circulate a copy of the register internationally; Ba insists that the first copy remain in the village. The order symbolically establishes local stewardship. Knowledge may reach overseas universities, but the originating community should not lose control of its record. This is a significant relation between Mithila's local memory and transnational scholarship. Yet the governance of the original, the consent of victims or families, and procedures for correction are not fully articulated. The symbolic assertion of community ownership marks the beginning of that work rather than an exhaustive archival protocol.

Unease among the Opposing Parties

Batuknath, Chandrapal and Raghav are unsettled by the village's failure to respond with the expected appeals, uproar or proposals for compromise. The quiet labour of writing names falls outside their accustomed model of legal and commercial opposition. Alternating scenes set letters made with turmeric and kajal against the monitoring of clients and signals. This parallel editing clarifies the disproportion between the objectives involved: one group seeks to preserve human presence, while the other tries to regain control over a market and a dispute. No invented confrontation is needed; the contrast between simultaneous activities carries the dramatic burden.

Overall Assessment: The Birth of an “Archive”

The strength of The Record of Names lies in the sensory detail of collective labour: selecting leaves, mixing ink, examining a granddaughter's photograph and a grandson's nail, resolving disputes over pronunciation, and teaching children the names. An enormous conspiracy narrative pauses long enough to occupy the act of writing in a small village. The difficulties are equally visible: inconsistencies in accounts of death, unequal kinds of evidence, and an incomplete scheme for durable preservation. Even with these qualifications, the name ceases to be only a

consoling metaphor. It becomes the subject of a specific communal institution in formation.

Critical Section 121 | Original Chapter 20 — A School Against the Screen

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From a Judicial Order to Education

On the day after the creation of the name register, a school begins in Channa Grove. The chronology makes visible the difference between the emotional force of the supernatural judgment and the social instruments needed for change. The villagers do not merely preserve the names of those already harmed; they attempt to reduce the likelihood of future deception. The concept of justice shifts from the punishment of particular offenders towards the practical question of protecting others. This is an important expansion from a plot organised around crime and revenge to one in which learning itself becomes a continuing narrative action.

From Children to Adults: An Expanding Audience

Children arrive first, followed by farmers, labourers, people opening bank accounts, students, mothers of sons working away from home, and elderly residents. The expanding audience rejects the assumption that digital fraud concerns only literate or technologically adept young people. Each group has a different reason to be afraid or vulnerable. The scene establishes a shared educational undertaking without claiming that everyone receives the message equally. Hearing an explanation, understanding its implications and changing one's behaviour are separate stages. By bringing many listeners together, the novel shows the possible reach of education while retaining the need to distinguish its actual effects.

Nishant's Metaphor of Four “Legs”

Nishant describes the screen crocodile as having four legs: greed, fear, shame and loneliness. The image offers a memorable practical classification, not a zoological account. It also provides a method of rereading Ujjwal's experience: the first reward encourages desire; debt produces fear; threatened disgrace becomes shame; and the sealed room brings isolation. Several earlier narrative episodes are compressed into these four terms. Such compression helps a spoken lesson travel from person to person, though it cannot account for every complexity of exploitation. The fourfold formula is a pedagogical device rather than an exhaustive theory of victimhood.

Ba's Answer: "Go to Your Own People"

An elderly listener asks where someone should run when danger appears. Ba replies: go to your own people. Cyber-safety instruction takes the form of a concrete relationship. Breaking isolation is the essential principle, but trusted people are not equally available to every victim; families themselves may respond with accusation. Meera later extends the answer by naming possible friends, teachers, sisters and supportive organisations. The chapter therefore revises its original maxim in the light of social difference. The important action is to find help, not to presume that every family constitutes a safe refuge.

Ananya's Lesson Written on a Leaf

Ananya writes "Do not remain alone" on a coconut leaf. Those unable to read hear the words; those unable to hear touch the lines of the leaf. The scene makes education sensory and multimodal rather than exclusively typographic. The leaf that carried names in the community archive now becomes a teaching text. Its changing function links remembrance to the prevention of new harm. This is not evidence that every accessibility barrier has been solved; rather, it is a fictional demonstration that knowledge can travel through hearing, touch and collective repetition as well as printed language.

Revising the Language of Shame

Meera initially utters an awkward, potentially confusing formulation about shame belonging to the offender, not the victim. Ba restates the lesson plainly: let the shame be the offender's. This small act of editing is a narrated event in its own right. The precision of a public maxim matters because an ambiguous sentence can reverse the intended responsibility. Instead of presenting a slogan as ready-made wisdom, the chapter shows its construction through conversation and correction. Literary style and public usefulness meet in the move from a difficult phrase to an intelligible shared utterance.

Nishant's Admission

Nishant says that overseas payment systems collected data about people's desires, fears, habits and loneliness. Questioned in the village, he acknowledges the responsibility implicit in what he failed to know or challenge. Devika instinctively wishes to speak on his behalf, but Ba allows him to answer for himself. The scene differentiates organised criminal conduct, a technical employee's failure to ask necessary questions, and an ordinary account holder's ignorance. They are not identical kinds of involvement. Nishant's admission matters because responsibility becomes

something a person must articulate rather than a blanket condemnation imposed on everyone connected with a technological system.

"If You Understand Your Mistake, Correct It"

Soumya proposes a serious heading concerning blame and responsibility; Ba chooses a simpler popular sentence: if you recognise a mistake, correct it. The change does not automatically trivialise complex financial and ethical questions. It offers an entry into them through a form that ordinary listeners can remember and repeat. Learned terminology and public speech occupy different levels, neither wholly replacing the other. The novel traces the social journey of an idea through a short utterance, while leaving its fuller ramifications open to further discussion and action.

The First Successful Interruption

A cousin of Munna Paswan questions an offer to open a bank account. He asks where the money will originate, why his name is needed, and who will control the telephone. He withdraws from the suspicious transaction and comes to the grove. The story presents intervention before the person has become fully trapped. In this new use of the word saved, someone who avoids the transaction is praised as alert rather than mocked as gullible. One event makes education's preventive possibility visible; it does not constitute evidence that fraud has ended throughout the region.

A Notice against an Unregistered School

Batuknath considers stopping the school through legal notice or a public-interest petition. Yet he cannot readily identify its formal target: there is no registered institution, president, bank account, permanent building or clear administrative office. The tree, its leaves and the villagers' informal gathering constitute a different kind of organised capacity. The scene imagines the tactical advantage of this informality within the fiction. It does not establish a universal legal principle that unregistered initiatives can never incur obligations or be subject to lawful regulation.

Education Travels Beyond the Village

The lessons are repeated at markets, weddings, funerary gatherings, bus stations, tea stalls in Madhubani, lodgings in Darbhanga and rented rooms in Delhi. This chain of places moves the school beyond the boundaries of a fixed classroom. The end of a lesson and the beginning of its social journey are distinct moments. People return home and repeat the warnings in their own idioms, linking the new teaching to the many-voiced folk culture established by the novel's prologue. The resulting spread is described through scenes of circulation, not an independently measured educational campaign.

The Ghosts Imagine Having Less Work

Burhbā observes that if living children are learning, the community of the dead may eventually have less work to do. Hulasi hopes fewer new spirits will arrive. This is a moving inversion: the ghostly assembly wishes to diminish rather than increase its own membership. Preventing harm among the living becomes the highest purpose of remembrance among the dead. The passage reinterprets folk belief in social terms. Its hope is genuine within the story, although no precise future reduction in deaths is demonstrated.

A Changed Form of Everyday Greeting

"Are you alone?" becomes an ordinary form of greeting. A small linguistic change encourages attention to an early sign of danger. The crocodile of fraud had severed people from their names and relationships; the communal question reconnects them with others. Yet the popularity of a protective saying and the statistical decline of digital crime cannot be treated as identical outcomes. The chapter supplies a few examples of practical response, not a comprehensive survey. Its point is the possible formation of a social habit of care.

Overall Assessment

A School Against the Screen turns from sensational exposure towards everyday public education. Children's questions, older people's confusion, Nishant's acknowledgement, Meera's alternative paths to support and Munna's cousin avoiding a dubious account all have distinct narrative functions. The spread of resistance can occasionally seem unusually effortless, but the scenes in which language is negotiated give the chapter lived dramatic texture. Its central contribution is to show that a community's response to exploitation must include prevention, not simply the identification and punishment of those already accused.

Critical Section 122 | Original Chapter 21 — The Pledge of Privacy

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From a School to a Pledge

After the name register and the lessons in screen safety, tranquillity might have been expected. Instead, the chapter observes how difficult it is for peace to grow in soil still saturated with shame and fear. Devika's and Soumya's experiences give rise to the idea of a collective pledge. Education passes from knowing what danger looks like to committing oneself to help others face it. The principle of refusing to blame victims acquires a physical setting: a circle drawn on the earth, within which people promise trust and assistance. This is not a repetition of the school lesson but an informal rite of shared responsibility.

Devika's Sleeplessness and the Blaming of the Dead

Although Ujjwal's name has been inscribed on the third leaf, Devika cannot sleep. Earlier village remarks suggesting that he was responsible for his own fate continue to accuse him even after death. She tries to redirect the language of explanation from supposed personal weakness towards the exploitative network surrounding him. Her troubled voice is a source of experiential knowledge, yet the moral language of grief should not be confused with a final judicial determination of criminal liability. The insomnia records the enduring effects of social blame. Inscription has preserved the name but cannot, by itself, quiet the bereaved person's struggle with public judgement.

The Reality of Meera's Renewed Fear

Meera, who has already spoken against privacy-based blackmail, becomes afraid again before returning to the village. The recurrence is not a failure of character development: a person who has once acted courageously does not become permanently fearless. A new threat arriving under a blurred identity demonstrates the persistence of social violence. Meera continues to understand her love as a private right, while fearing its exploitation by an economic network. The episode gives her confidence a fluctuating trajectory rather than the artificial finality of a single triumphant declaration.

Three Words within the Circle

Soumya writes privacy, Devika fraud, and Meera shame in the red earth. The words represent different levels of experience: individual rights, organised exploitation and its social reflection. The circle offers an equal space for listening, but the women within it have not undergone identical harms. Their unity consists in identifying one another's sources of fear without erasing those distinctions. The words written on the ground make abstract rights visible as a collective undertaking. A form familiar from the grove's ceremonies becomes a setting in which ethical obligations are named by the participants themselves.

Giving Munna the Opportunity to Speak

Munna Paswan stands at the edge of the gathering and explains that he opened an account in return for five thousand rupees. He says he does not know the broker's true name, yet his own name has appeared in a police investigation. Meera proposes that a name should serve to protect a person, rather than to impose guilt without scrutiny. This requires preserving differences between being a victim, being an account holder used by others and bearing possible legal responsibility. The story does not establish Munna's absolute innocence; it insists that what he knew and what others intended are not automatically the same.

A Difficult Question from Ananya's Schoolmate

A schoolgirl asks what to do if a threatening image might be made public and then asks what happens if her family scolds her. The child's questions force an appealing slogan to face everyday circumstances. Devika recommends telling someone trustworthy, not sending money and not destroying the messages. Meera promises that families who blame their children must also be educated. The lesson moves from principle into actionable forms of assistance. Yet it cannot guarantee that every household will respond safely. The narrative's strength is that its own younger listeners expose an important limit in the first, simple formulations.

Ira Listening from a Distance

From abroad, Ira watches a small mobile-phone image of the circle drawn in the grove's soil. The scene contrasts university ethics with fear experienced by real people. Ira does not repudiate scholarship; she recognises that its effectiveness is tested in the ways frightened individuals support one another. This distant focalisation makes a local village assembly the centre of a question with international implications. The moral significance of the meeting is not conferred by Harvard's approval.

Rather, the university-trained observer must learn from forms of practical responsibility taking shape elsewhere.

Nishant Acknowledges Fear

In a foreign financial office, Nishant understands portions of the payment routes but acknowledges his own fear. Soumya suggests using that fear as a reason for caution rather than demanding its complete disappearance. Their exchange gives courage a more complicated meaning. Heroism is not simply the absence of anxiety; the important question is whether the person can recognise fear and act responsibly without surrendering judgement to it. Nishant's intentions and his limits as an investigator remain distinct. The scene does not pretend that acknowledging fear grants him complete knowledge of the network.

The Collective Declaration "We Are Not Guilty"

Those who have received threats come to the grove, draw circles and speak against the burden of guilt imposed upon them. Private self-reproach becomes a shared public language. The scene seeks to shift shame from the people coerced or threatened towards the sources of their abuse. Yet "We are not guilty" is a pledge of mutual support, not a formal ruling absolving every participant of every contractual or financial liability. In the novel's literary economy, its power lies in what it permits people to say and do together. It rejects indiscriminate victim-blaming without abolishing necessary distinctions among kinds of responsibility.

Hulasi and Meera's Silence at Night

After the gathering, Meera remains alone in the grove. She remembers Aditi, her beloved, who has not yet gathered the courage to visit the village. Hulasi's unseen companionship gives the moment its tenderness. The public pledge has not removed all traces of private fear. This is an important act of narrative restraint: a collective movement may provide support while leaving individual loneliness and unsettled relationships in existence. Meera's inner life is not sacrificed to the simplicity of a victorious social ceremony. Her solitude is retained as part of the truth of her development.

Soumya's Enlargement of the Language of Rights

Soumya's remarks speak of bodily autonomy among homosexual and heterosexual people, the married and unmarried, women and men, and people of a third gender. The original focus on women's vulnerability broadens into a question of dignity across different lives. Listing these groups, however, is not equivalent to developing a distinct narrative for each of them. The chapter announces an enlarged moral perimeter; it does

not thereby achieve complete characterisation of every social position named. Criticism should recognise the significance of this ethical widening while refusing to confuse programmatic inclusion with fully realised fictional experience.

Ujjwal's Mother's Public Voice

When a young man facing a fraudulent threat comes to the school and avoids sending money, Ujjwal's mother speaks publicly for the first time. She says that, had a safe gathering like this existed earlier, perhaps her son might have voiced his fear. The statement is a grieving mother's impossible if: the past cannot be changed. Her experience differs from Devika's determined work of investigation, although both speak in relation to the same lost person. The chapter thereby preserves more than one mode of mourning within a family. Prevention for the living does not cancel the irreversibility of the earlier loss.

Phones, Chests and Earth Instead of a Sacred Book

During the concluding pledge, participants place their hands on telephones, their own chests and the ground on which names have been written. Technology, body and geography meet in a new communal rite. The phone is no longer solely an instrument of deception; it can also preserve threatened testimony. The scene does not reject devices but brings them into a practice governed by human responsibility. An older Mithila tradition of collective speech encounters contemporary tools without becoming their passive extension. The ritual's literary meaning is grounded in this changing use of ordinary objects.

Overall Assessment: Support before Justice

The Pledge of Privacy follows the growth of social trust in a setting where fear and shame still remain. Its circle of three words, Munna's account, the schoolgirl's questions, Meera's surviving anxiety and the first public words of Ujjwal's mother give the chapter several centres of attention. Some of its moral statements are unusually explicit, yet hesitation and dialogue keep the characters from becoming mere slogans. Its most significant achievement is the building of relationships through which victims can seek help without being blamed, while the irreversible absence of the dead remains painfully visible.

Critical Section 123 | Original Chapter 22 — The Second Harvard Lecture

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

A Different Dramatic Arrangement for the Second Lecture

Edward Broom prepares another address on global enterprise and dignity. In the earlier Harvard chapter Ira asked a specific question from within the auditorium. This time, despite being invited, she decides not to ask a question. Her silence is not presented as submission to fear. It belongs to a plan to move resistance outside the rules of the official platform. The story therefore avoids a simple repetition of the first debate: it rearranges the medium through which the dispute will be heard. The relation between a university's discourse and the villagers' recitation of names becomes the decisive structural issue.

The Smell of the Village in Cambridge

Among Cambridge's old brick buildings, an imagined damp smell from the Kamala–Balan rises despite the absence of visible water. This magical sensory transfer creates a path of memory between distant places. Smell is not presented as a scientific mechanism for sending information; it is a means by which the narrative makes suffering from the village perceptible in a modern overseas setting. Neither place loses its particular economic or historical circumstances. Their difference is essential to the literary force of the unexpected fragrance.

Gold Letters, Clean Flowers and Slides

Posters in the hall display dignity and responsibility in gold lettering; flowers and carefully arranged slides decorate the stage. Outside, a modest row of people gathers around names. Broom's presentation moves from the bridge to the hospital and school, then to the word trust. Each slide calls earlier stories of worker deaths and the pandemic back into the reader's mind. The mere presence of luxury and polished graphics is not proof of wrongdoing. The dramatic irony arises from the contrast between these public images and the history already narrated behind them.

Declining the Invitation to Ask a Question

Elina Graves expects Ira to ask a question. Ira answers no. Within the conventions of a respectable university question-and-answer session, a challenge might be phrased as a polite query, receive a broad response and disappear into controlled applause. Ira chooses to work outside that

circular procedure. Her decision marks an ideological development: unacknowledged labourers must not remain merely a topic of courteous disagreement in the auditorium. Their names need an independent public space in which they can be heard without the invited speaker determining the terms of their appearance.

A Small Counter-Stage on the Steps Outside

With three students and two elderly women, Ira places a computer, camera and audio equipment on the stone steps outside the hall. The improvised platform is not a formally constituted assembly; it is a site from which local names will be heard at a distance. Crucially, Ira does not read the names herself. She serves as a guardian of transmission rather than displacing the village's own voices. This restraint in representation is one of the scene's strongest narrative choices. The person with access to an international platform lends that access without claiming ownership of the testimony it carries.

Ananya Leads the Cry of "Present"

In Garh Narikel, Ananya reads from the leaf register while the children answer "Present" after each name. Sarayu Devi, Kanhaiya Paswan, Ujjwal Jha, an unnamed woman and an unnamed elderly person from the pandemic are included in one act of communal listening. The different categories receive honour, but their differences do not vanish. Calling an unidentified person present cannot reconstruct an unrecorded identity, revise a death certificate or settle a cause of death. "Present" is a promise of public remembrance, not an administrative claim that the dead have returned to biological life.

The Return of Munna's Name

The children call Munna not by his bank-account number but as Munna Paswan. The detail recalls the mule-account episode and restores the social identity of a person trapped in a numerical network. Being an account holder, being exploited by an organised scheme and bearing potential legal responsibility remain distinct questions. The act of naming does not amount to a court order declaring him innocent. Its literary purpose is to refuse the reduction of a person to the single technical function an exploitative system assigned him.

Names Appear Spontaneously on the Screen

The projected photograph of the bridge gives way to names upon a wet leaf. A technician attempts to correct the apparent malfunction, but the names reappear. This extraordinary image is framed as magical realism's insistence upon indestructible memory, not as a technical account of a

cyber-intrusion. The knowledge of the spectators also differs: some may observe a changing screen, whereas the sound of a splash from the Ganges may belong specifically to Broom's terror. Maintaining these differences prevents the supernatural episode from being mistaken for a completed forensic demonstration.

The Parallel Sounds of "Inside" and "Outside"

Inside the auditorium the speaker discusses ethical frameworks, dignity and responsibility. Outside, the children's voices make the names of dead workers audible. Through this sound montage, the narrative demands practical answers to ethical abstractions. The crowded interior seems morally empty, while the small gathering outside becomes a space of meaningful presence. This reversal has a structural kinship with The Empty Court: the institution continues its proceedings, but the centre of ethical attention moves beyond its walls. The story questions who controls the location and rhythm of public speech.

Elina Crosses the Threshold

Professor Elina Graves leaves the stage area and moves towards the door; students gradually follow her to the steps. The action represents a limited but meaningful personal change. Read against her earlier role in defending institutional convention, her quiet departure suggests ethical discomfort and a willingness to listen. Nevertheless, one occasion of leaving a hall does not show that an entire university has altered its relation to donors and institutional power. The narrative presents a gesture of reconsideration, not a verified structural reform.

Not a Principal Individual but a Village

Lau Kin-Hung orders the source to be shut down. Raghav replies that sources are numerous and there is no single principal person to target. Distributed participation becomes a major feature of the story. What previously depended on figures such as Gop, Nand and Ira now circulates through children, women, leaves and copies of records. This makes control more difficult. Yet the particular work of Ananya, Devika and Ira should not be erased in celebrating the absence of a single purchasable leader. The movement is dispersed, not magically devoid of human organisers.

The Proposal of an Empty Stage

Elina asks what she can do. Ira suggests that at the next such lecture the stage should be left empty. The proposal transforms withdrawal from a platform into a form of ethical refusal: an empty lectern might speak against the terms of the authorised address. At this point it is a suggestion for a future event. The narrative does not depict a fully implemented

boycott or an empty stage on the present occasion. The distinction between proposal and realised action is essential to assessing Ira's agency and its actual consequences.

The Old Teeth behind a New Corporate Name

The following week Broom's company changes its name. Public reports portray the change as a new beginning; children in the village compare it to a crocodile retaining its old teeth. Rebranding becomes a question about responsibility rather than a final transformation of the enterprise. The children's response insists that a change in nomenclature cannot itself erase the company's past. This name change is an event within the novel; it must not be imported uncritically as a claim about an identifiable real-world corporation.

Overall Assessment: An Alternative Rhythm of Questioning

The most significant achievement of The Second Harvard Lecture is its relocation of narrative control. Ira's first intervention took the form of a question inside the hall; the second is an act of transmission outside it, giving precedence to children's voices from the village. Names appearing on the projection, Elina's departure, Raghav's discovery that there is no single leader, and the corporate name change construct a dramatic sequence. The immediate reach of resistance can at moments seem surprisingly effortless. Yet Ira's decision to step behind the voices she enables marks a genuine maturity in the novel's ethics of representation.

Critical Section 124 | Original Chapter 23 — Batuknath's Search

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Victor's Journey to the Village for an Opposite Purpose

Batuknath travels to Garh Narikel carrying the document of his procedural victory, expecting to find the people he imagines defeated. Instead, he encounters them not in a waiting room for fresh protests but at work in a school that records names on leaves. The reversal gives concrete form to the earlier theme of The Grief of Victory. The opposing party's social independence alters his assumed relationship of power. He meets not threats or excited slogans but an almost unbearable ordinariness: people continue their work without organising their lives around the importance he assigns to his order.

The Grove Becomes a Place of Work

On long bamboo boards, children dry coconut leaves and record names. The same ground has been a field for play, a court for ghosts, a circle for education and now an archival workshop. The narrator does not leave place as an immobile cultural emblem. Its functions change as the community acts upon it. This practical continuity disturbs Batuknath because his plan depends on a protesting crowd awaiting his decisions, whereas he finds something more like an autonomous school. Place acquires narrative history through its changing uses.

A Girl's Question about His Own Name

A girl asks Batuknath whether his name has been written. The question reveals two possible functions of the communal record. A name may be preserved in gratitude or mourning, but it may also be retained as a warning. The simplicity of the maxim that all names deserve remembrance now requires critical differentiation. Batuknath's prominence no longer guarantees honour; it turns him into a possible subject of examination. By putting this question into the mouth of a child, the narrative transfers evaluative authority away from the socially powerful without staging an immediate formal trial.

The Irony of Ananya's Request to Wait

Batuknath asks to meet Aruni. Ananya replies that he has gone to read names and tells the visitor to wait. Her remark that he must have learned waiting in court is restrained but sharp irony. The scene refuses revenge

through physical violence or public uproar. Instead, the man who practised and prolonged delay must experience time imposed by someone else. The old symbol of judicial postponement returns as a child's casual sentence. This does not amount to a legal sanction; it is a precise redistribution of the experience of waiting.

Devika Insists on Speaking before Everyone

Devika arrives with copies concerning digital fraud, false arrest threats, family testimony and other young people's experiences. Batuknath proposes a confidential conversation, but she makes speaking in everyone's presence a condition. Earlier threats and manipulations have rendered isolation suspect in this particular relationship of power. This choice does not contradict Meera's earlier insistence on protecting private information. Devika chooses publicity when dealing with an opposing lawyer; Meera chooses confidentiality for intimate personal details. The narrative's ethical precision depends on treating public and private speech as contextual choices rather than universal obligations.

Different Meanings of Compensation and Remembrance

Batuknath offers assistance with compensation. Devika rejects the possibility that her brother's name might be assigned a price in exchange for forgetting. She is not thereby renouncing the need for lawful redress or financial support to victims' families. The criticism is directed against using money to purchase the end of public memory. Compensation and respect may be complementary forms of response, but they are not interchangeable. Her suspicion of this particular offer is rooted in the earlier conduct of the man making it. The scene's meaning depends upon that history, not upon a general hostility to all remedies.

Meera's Distinction between Suppressing and Ending

Batuknath suggests managing the case of private information by suppressing it through legal means. Meera distinguishes between concealing the affair and ending the network's ability to misuse stolen material. Confidentiality can protect a victim's rights; secrecy can also hide the sources of abuse. The exchange makes the difference audible through competing verbs. Meera remains courteous, even bidding him farewell, but does not surrender her decision from fear. Her restraint is a form of self-command, not acquiescence to the lawyer's version of what her interests require.

The Question of a Movement without a Leader

Batuknath messages Chandrapal that he sees neither leader nor demand nor visible fear in the village. Chandrapal interprets this as the

disappearance of danger, whereas Batuknath recognises a more difficult challenge. Their disagreement exposes different assumptions within the opposing network: Chandrapal seeks familiar signs that can be controlled, while Batuknath has encountered social labour no longer organised around a purchasable single leader. Particular people remain active organisers, but the community does not fit the structure of an opposition that can be neutralised by buying or intimidating one individual.

The Pond as a Mirror for "Procedure"

Looking into the pond, Batuknath sees the word procedure instead of his own face. When he touches the water, its letters break into hundreds of names. The magical mirror confronts his technical legal expertise with the people displaced by it. He would like to preserve his professional identity as a neutral system of rules; the pond makes that identity answer to histories he has helped obscure. The vision is an image of private fear, not a published confession. Its symbolic force lies in the transformation of an abstract occupational vocabulary into the presence of particular human beings.

Ananya's Boat and the Future of a Blank Settlement

Batuknath produces an unfilled settlement document. Ananya folds it into a paper boat and places it on the pond, where it becomes wet and sinks. The girl understands that water will not sustain a paper without names. This reverses earlier images of boats fashioned from coconut leaves and of documentary currents. The episode does not declare every paper document false. It criticises the specific manoeuvre of obtaining a signature before disclosing whose name or interests the agreement will concern. The missing human subject becomes visible through the fragile object.

A Different Victory for "Free People"

Batuknath recognises that the villagers no longer make opposition to him the centre of their lives. Devika teaches, Meera assists through the privacy circle, Gop preserves copies, Nishant explains payment routes and Ira creates channels for speaking abroad. Their varied activities displace the binary of the lawyer's formal victory and his opponents' defeat. Yet beginning such work does not mean that exploitation has ended. The term free names an emergent social possibility, not an established condition of complete liberation. The narrative measures agency through continuing action rather than a final slogan.

A Name Spoken as a Warning

In the ghosts' game that night, the name Batuknath is called not in remembrance of a dead victim but as a warning. The scene exposes a

classificatory problem within the novel's ethic of preserving names. Not everyone recorded is a victim or an honoured ancestor. Registers must distinguish those who have died, living witnesses, people accused of exploitation and cautionary entries. Without such distinctions the moral dignity of remembrance could be clouded by a confused list. This is a rare moment in which the project of recording names interrogates its own categories.

A Message Deleted before It Can Be Sent

As Batuknath returns to the city, he begins a message to Chandrapal saying that the affair can proceed without him. He deletes it instead of sending it. This self-suppressed utterance separates internal recognition from public admission. He has understood something about the changing situation but lacks the courage to state it and act accordingly. His silence contrasts with the chosen silence of Ira, which enables new speech, and the women's strategic silences, which protect autonomy. Here silence serves self-preservation; the difference is crucial to the character's incomplete development.

Overall Conclusion: Who Is Doing the Searching?

Batuknath's Search presents moral defeat not through fierce retaliatory violence but through fruitless meetings and an unaccepted agreement. Ananya's irony, Devika's insistence on open conversation, Meera's courteous resistance, the word appearing in the pond, the paper boat and the unsent message together shape an internal crisis. The novel does not pronounce Batuknath reformed; he still keeps the document of his victory in his cupboard. This incompletion makes the character more credible even though repeated supernatural punishment occasionally becomes insistent. The title's question turns back upon its subject: the man ostensibly searching for his defeated opponents has begun to encounter the limits of his own identity.

Inter-Sectional Conclusion: The Integrated Narrative Design of Chapters 16–23

Across these eight chapters the novel constructs a second kind of judicial world. Channa Grove's ghostly court first turns suppressed testimony into the drama of punishments through remembrance. The procedural victor's grief, the apparently empty courthouse, names written on leaves, a school teaching screen safety, the privacy pledge, the counter-stage in Cambridge and Batuknath's futile search then reveal an expanding sphere of social agency. The crocodile's teeth, dark accounts and institutional rhetoric had formed an overarching political metaphor. Against them, awakening develops as a dispersed practice, local, many-voiced and grounded in

experience. The strongest scenes are often very small: a child slowly correcting the letter of Sarayu's name, a cleaner writing his father's name, Munna's cousin asking questions at the bank, Meera's persisting fear, Ira standing aside from her own microphone, and Ananya turning an unsigned paper into a boat. These modest gestures transform a great denunciation of criminal networks into a story about the reconstruction of living society.

Important inconsistencies must nevertheless remain visible. The account of Ujjwal's death in Chapters 8 and 16 is not identical; Sarayu's identity and family circumstances are not fully consistent across episodes; and the judicial relationship between the protective interim order of Chapter 15 and Batuknath's later procedural "victory" in Chapters 17–19 lacks a definitive clarification. The criticism cannot invent an appeal, a second lawsuit or a reconciled biography to eliminate those differences. Supernatural penalties in the grove, formal orders in Delhi, the community's civil register and accusations made by characters belong to four distinguishable narrative levels. Keeping them separate allows magical realism, documentary violence and social education to illuminate one another without losing their different kinds of authority beneath an undifferentiated claim of truth.

Critical Section 125 | Original Chapter 24 — The Novel Begins Again

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

Announced Endings versus Narrative Continuity

The previous chapters ended the court of Channa Grove, left Batuknath's victory document in his cupboard and placed an empty page before Ananya. Chapter 24 converts these apparent endings into means of beginning again. It is not merely the next event in sequence but an occasion on which the novel examines its own rules of construction. Aruni wants to write an ending, yet village life continues beyond his authorial control. The children's game and their collective recitation of names replace the writer's pen as the visible agents of renewal. The result is an act of self-correction: the narrator's declaration of closure confronts the persistence of social life.

Dewdrops Read the Leaves

At the opening, dew seems to read the previous night's decisions written upon the grove's leaves; the suggestion arises that false lines will disappear under sunlight. The natural world is endowed with the magical capacity of an ethical editor. A leaf is no longer merely archival material but an active reader and examiner of a judgement. Yet this miraculous selection of falsehood cannot serve as a real method of factual verification. The inconsistencies already present elsewhere in the novel do not disappear because the fiction imagines sunlight selecting truthful lines. The literary image strengthens the duty to scrutinise the record, without replacing that scrutiny with magic.

The Meeting of Old and New Lines

Ananya draws a new kabaddi boundary over the old boundary used by the ghosts. A wooden stick, wet earth and a line half-buried under dust make the relationship between generations bodily and visible. The new game does not annihilate the earlier one; it rewrites the shared ground. Living children inherit the ghosts' play but are not condemned merely to imitate it. When Ananya declares that the game is beginning, the authority to initiate action lies in her hands. The repetition is thus progressive: the older circle is not a fixed orbit, and the new line can choose another direction.

Somit's Turn and the Silence of Mourning

Somit, Munna's nephew, holds his breath and says Ujjwal Jha's name three times. Devika links the memory of her brother with the experience of recognising fraudulent screen-based schemes. The children do not applaud: some names demand silence more than celebration. Play, bereavement and education are carefully balanced in this scene. A child's breath is brief, while the spoken name gains continuity in collective listening. There is nevertheless a danger that Ujjwal's tragic death may be reduced to a lesson for others. Devika's personal grief prevents the episode from becoming only an instructional example.

Sarayu's Signature upon the Body of the Earth

Another girl calls Sarayu's name, returns and places her hand upon the soil. Devika interprets the damp mark as the earth's signature on behalf of a woman denied literacy. This is an expansive metaphor for an archive: where a worker's handwriting is missing from official records, the physical trace of labour becomes testimony on the land itself. The uncanny mark is not scientific handwriting evidence that a court could simply authenticate. At the literary level, the right to inscribe moves from state paper towards workers' ground. Sarayu gains another place in memory, though the earlier contradictions surrounding her biography remain unresolved.

Thirty and Three Hundred in a Collective Voice

An unseen player crosses the line crying that there are not merely thirty names but three hundred. The voice does not recite the whole list or complete the inquiry; it leaves work for the children. Numbers here are a question for the future, not the final settlement of an investigation. The tension between thirty officially recorded names and the larger disputed number has governed much of the novel. The call has moral force, but the figure of three hundred must not be presented as a verified final count merely because it is voiced collectively. Unfinished work is the narrative device that keeps the next generation active.

A New Line Appears on Batuknath's Order

In the city cupboard, beside the words indicating the dismissal of a petition, Batuknath's damp order acquires another line: “Public work begins.” The uncanny addition returns to the earlier legal tension. The protective order in Chapter 15, the procedural victory asserted in Chapter 17, and the dismissal described in Chapter 24 do not have a sufficiently clear legal chronology. The new magical line elevates the community's undertaking, but it cannot resolve those procedural inconsistencies by itself. Critical reading must preserve the gaps rather than inventing an intermediate appeal or separate case to fill them.

Criminal Fear as the Measure of Resistance Changes

Chandrapal receives a report describing fewer new mule accounts over seven days, five young people lodging complaints, and some people disconnecting false-arrest calls. These small examples make educational consequences visible. The chapter does not assert that an immense network has been destroyed. Lau Kin-Hung orders his associates to “buy education,” revealing a form of power that treats learning as another commodity to acquire. A grandmother's story and a child's warning, however, cannot be removed by a single purchase. The structural contrast is between vast orders issued by a remote financier and the modest actions of particular members of the community.

A School on Four Sides

The school of coconut leaves is organised into four areas: an archive of names, lessons in screen safety, a privacy pledge and song. Spatial arrangement turns earlier narrative threads into a social curriculum. Without claiming the status of a permanent school building, the grove becomes an active centre of shared work. Each living child speaks a personal name together with that of a dead person, linking self-identification and communal responsibility in a single utterance. The risk remains that lessons may harden into slogans without addressing unequal vulnerabilities; Nishant's incomplete answers point towards the need for deeper, differentiated inquiry.

The Unfinished Question of Ishan's Shadow

Chapter 15 suggested that part of Ishan's shadow had returned. Here daylight falls in Channa Grove, but his shadow still fails to become complete. Questioned by Ananya, Ishan speaks about reversing his recorded death and rewriting his life within community memory. This recurrence represents an identity not yet recovered. The earlier partial return and the present assertion of continuing absence are not perfectly harmonised in temporal terms. They may be read as stages in a difficult recovery, or as a minor textual disjunction. The criticism must not pronounce one explanation certain without further support from the text.

Living Players and Reassured Ghosts

In the evening, Devika, Meera, Nishant, Soumya, Gop and Aruni take turns in the game. In the first chapter the ghosts played while the living were frightened; now living people play and the ghosts watch with reassurance. The narrator presents the reversal as a new birth for the novel. It is a transfer of agency, not merely an exchange of places. The dead no longer carry the whole burden of remembrance, because the living answer through communal action. The direct ethical lesson attached to each turn

can occasionally limit interpretive openness, but the structural reversal gives the sequence a genuine narrative result.

Hulasi's Incomplete Letter and Loth's Changed Posture

For the first time Hulasi's indistinct hand writes the incomplete letter "ja" in the earth; Loth feels the desire to rise. The half-formed syllable allows the sounds and meanings of knowledge, awakening, birth and water to meet without closing into one definition. Instead of furnishing a complete identity, the writer leaves language unfinished. This very incompleteness signals a possible easing of the burden carried by the spirits. No definitive redemption or liberation of all ghosts is declared. Loth's changed bearing also recalls the limited voice he acquired earlier in the grove's court.

The Empty Coconut and the Seed of Tulsi

A coconut contains emptiness instead of water. From it emerges a small leaf bearing the suggestion that a story does not end when a name is read. At dawn, an ordinary village woman takes the fruit home and places a tulsi seed within it. This is one of the chapter's strongest images. Magical emptiness becomes the possibility of daily planting; the word travels into the metaphor of a seed. Rather than displaying the extraordinary leaf as a unique sacred relic, an unnamed woman converts it into an ordinary domestic beginning. The novel's large abstractions find their continuation in a modest act of cultivation.

A Self-Conscious Ending to the Chapter

Aruni hands his notebook to Ananya. She writes that kabaddi has been played again in Channa Grove and that this time the captured participant was falsehood. The book directly comments upon who has the right to narrate its events. Although the reader is only at Chapter 24, the scene produces an ending resembling that of a complete novel. Such repeated self-closure is an identifiable technique that subsequent chapters must continue to test. Its achievement is the child's fresh line resisting an adult writer's exclusive control. Its danger lies in declarations so explicit that the movement of events can seem to pause. One further restraint is decisive: fraudulent apps continue to operate, people are still deceived, and no society has been liberated in a single night.

Critical Section 126 | Original Chapter 25 — The Mind Left Hanging

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From Visible Action to Psychological Recurrence

The principal event of The Mind Left Hanging is not an external judicial hearing but the uncontrolled activity of sleep and memory among the implicated characters. Batuknath's victory order, Chandrapal's law degree, Raghav's deleted messages, Lau's financial map and Broome's ethical speeches are different objects, yet each becomes a surface on which suppressed names appear. The chapter edits mental scenes from distant locations into a parallel sequence. Those whom the protagonists oppose remain narratively present even when the village falls silent around them; their inward disturbances make the absent victims audible. What changes is not the formal status of the legal case but the location of narrative pressure: from publicly displayed documents towards the unstable private consciousness of those claiming mastery over them.

The Private Fear of the Cupboard Key

Batuknath draws the key kept beneath his pillow and opens the cupboard containing the order that signifies his victory. The locked room, carefully protected papers and arrangement of private possessions were meant to guarantee security; instead, the rustling paper disturbs him. Words appear and disappear as he examines the document. The text thus stages unstable guilt rather than producing an objectively revised legal record. Batuknath's laughter is an immediate defensive response, an attempt to turn fear into a joke. It should not be mistaken for satisfaction with justice. The cupboard and key, supposedly signs of mastery over procedure, become instruments through which procedure ceases to provide the inward refuge he expects from it.

The Earlier History of Chandrapal's Degree

On the glass covering Chandrapal's law degree from Meerut, the phrase “first mule” appears. The credential that he has treated as evidence of professional and moral standing becomes a screen for the memory of his initial involvement with suspect financial arrangements. This does not reduce his entire biography to that of an innately corrupt lawyer. Instead, the uncanny writing opens a route towards the stages by which professional knowledge, consultancy and the circulation of money became interconnected. A phrase appearing on glass is neither a complete account

of an offence nor an independently verified document. Its function is to make a privileged object of professional self-recognition bear the weight of a history its owner would prefer to suppress.

Raghav's Voice Sent by Himself

Raghav trusts the rule that messages which disappear will leave no surviving record. A voice message nevertheless arrives with its sender identified as "self." He recognises his own voice but cannot control the sound of weeping in its background. This is an audible division of the self. A person whose habitual practice was to erase spoken traces is made to hear speech he cannot contain. Within the fictional world, the event belongs to its supernatural register. It does not establish a specific technical intrusion, recovered audio file or authenticated sequence of recordings. The scene's force lies in the reversal of a chosen condition of invisibility: the manager of other people's frightening messages must now endure the sound of his own precarious voice.

Lau's Failure to Reduce Understanding to a Percentage

In his distant maritime office, Lau sees Garh Narikela as a minute point on a screen, yet the rise in searches concerning resistance and the anxiety over declining customers challenge his habitual model of control. He orders names or understanding to be purchased because an autonomous human relationship makes little sense within calculations of revenue. His difficulty is a reversal of the confidence associated with the network's financial centre. The novel does not claim that the circulation of public knowledge has instantly destroyed the entire international fraud operation. It shows that the habits by which Lau measures and purchases influence are encountering something they cannot readily price. The character's weakness is epistemic and emotional before it becomes an established commercial outcome.

The Names of the Dead Beneath Broome's Ethical Words

Broome reads his carefully edited speech, whose terms include dignity and transparency. Beneath each English expression, Devanagari names become visible. The scene offers an unsettling reversal of translation: the elevated language of transnational commerce is made to carry the local individuals whose lives its publicity has obscured. Broome still speaks the vocabulary of public ethics, but in his private distress those words acquire an accusatory underside. This must not be presented as an officially altered transcript of a university address. It is a representation of the character's perceptual disturbance and of the novel's insistence that moral terminology cannot remain wholly separate from the lives hidden beneath it. The visual doubling exposes a disjunction, not an adjudicated confession.

Satyavrat's Question about the Blank Spaces

Reading a printed copy of the register of names, Satyavrat finds empty spaces beside entries for dates of birth, death, incidents and suppressed details. These omissions signify more than the imperfection of an archive: they are an agenda for future verification. The state lawyer begins to understand that accountability requires recovering something of the historical life of each person, not merely reproducing an accusatory list. The narrative's refusal to fill every field is formally important. It does not pretend to have reconstructed all individual biographies. Preserving visible blanks prevents the memorial from becoming an appearance of exhaustive knowledge. An incomplete record can remain ethically responsible when it acknowledges what must still be investigated.

Ananya's Dream and Devika's Changing Lesson

Ananya's dream touches the intergenerational movement of the narrative, while Devika dreams of Ujjwal carrying a wooden writing board rather than a mobile telephone. Her dead brother's tragedy is being transformed into a practical lesson at the community school: disconnecting a call can itself require courage. The dream enables grief to become a source of protective instruction without undoing the death. For Devika, it offers moral support; for the village, a memorable warning; for the reader, another expression of the continuing burden of loss. It would be a serious distortion to read Ujjwal's appearance in sleep as a recovered living presence or as evidence that the personal and financial consequences of the fraud have been resolved.

Soumya's Social Work through Translation

Soumya makes English accounting notes, banking records and legal vocabulary intelligible in the language of ordinary villagers. Her attempt to explain “mule account” alongside a locally comprehensible expression is a particularly important scene in the novel's reflection on language. The unreadability of official paperwork can reinforce unequal power; translation helps reduce that inequality. Yet changing words does not automatically solve technical questions or establish the reliability of a transaction. A translated term must still be tested against its source and the circumstances to which it applies. Soumya's work therefore extends the struggle for names into the struggle for understandable public knowledge, providing a necessary human counterpart to spectacular supernatural interventions.

The Failure to Erase the Wrongdoers' Records

Chandrapal tries to tear up an old paper register; Raghav deletes messages; Batuknath tries to delimit the wording of an order. All three seek to

determine what can survive as a trace. The image of the returning leaf now enters the very documents that these characters thought they controlled. Impossible resistance to torn paper and the recurrence of erased messages express a moral desire that human memory should not be annihilated by deliberate deletion. They are not a claim about the actual technical permanence of all digital data. The formal parallel matters: earlier the victims struggled to retain fragile names; here those implicated in suppressing names discover that their own instruments are imagined as resistant to erasure.

Broome's Proposed Documentary on "Rural Resilience"

Broome's public-relations advisers propose incorporating Garh Narikela's opposition into a documentary on "rural resilience." This is a subtler possible means of control: turn an unruly movement into a marketable representation of its own endurance. Ira's answer shifts attention towards the duty of anyone arriving with a camera to read and attend to names. The struggle is over who controls the interpretation of visible resistance and whether image-making displaces the people represented. At this point, however, the film has not been shown to have been made, universally rejected by the village or approved by all concerned. The plan remains a proposed strategy; the resistance to representational appropriation is equally a stated response, not a completed production history.

Distinct Consciences among the Implicated Characters

The five principal antagonistic figures are frightened, but not in the same way. Batuknath worries about the meaning of his legal victory; Chandrapal confronts an old register; Raghav hears the return of his deleted voice; Lau questions the reliability of his profit map; Broome feels the ethical vocabulary of his speeches turning against him. Conflating all five into a single collective repentance would make the chapter less, not more, coherent. None has yet undertaken the decisive actions needed to abandon the enterprise or repair its harms. The chapter inhabits an interval of irritation, anxiety and possible self-recognition. Its psychology remains preliminary, leaving future conduct—not dreamlike fear—to test whether any moral change has occurred.

A New Path on the Leaf and the Opening of the Notebook

At dawn, Ananya sees a path instead of letters on a leaf: a narrow route leading into the grove and out again. The meaning of a line changes from the boundary of kabaddi or the route of financial payments to the movement of social experience. Aruni opens his notebook, and the story pauses at the threshold of another narrative strand. Against the density of the antagonists' inward terrors, the delicate path registers the active life

continuing beyond them. The gesture does not establish a completed solution or a secure future. It announces an opening through which new records, witnesses and decisions may enter. The contrast between the narrow visible line and the sprawling network of fear gives the section its compositional rhythm.

Overall Critical Assessment

The Mind Left Hanging derives its force from recurring scenes of mental disturbance. Papers, a degree, a voice recording, a map and a speech become unexpected vehicles of collective memory. The narrative enters the private rooms of those implicated in exploitation without granting them absolution through introspection alone. Its weakness is the frequent return of a nearly identical supernatural device: uncanny inscriptions threaten to obscure differences in individual psychology through repetition. The counterweight lies in Soumya's practical translation work and Ananya's path leading beyond the grove. These suggest that the living community's widening activity matters more than the terror experienced by its opponents. The chapter's achievement is to expose the fragility of apparent victory; it does not certify repentance or legal punishment.

Critical Section 127 | Original Chapter 26 — Batuknath Hariharan's Journey

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

From a Journey of the Mind to a Journey of the Body

Chapter 25 says that Batuknath's mind has been left hanging in Garh Narikela. Chapter 26 seems to give that psychological movement a corresponding physical journey by rail. The narrative passes from cupboard, key and victory order to station, carriage, river and village road. An important chronological difficulty must nevertheless be acknowledged: Chapter 23 already narrated Batuknath's arrival in the village and his return. The renewed suggestion of a first journey thus raises the possibility of a temporal inconsistency or a deliberately circular retelling. The source offers no decisive reconciliation. Faithful criticism must retain the discrepancy and examine what the repetition achieves rather than inventing a second itinerary, a flashback or an intervening event that the text does not identify.

The Cupboard Key and His Father's Spectacles

Batuknath carries the smell of the brass key held in his palm overnight, a leather bag, two pen drives, a sealed envelope and his father's old spectacles. These objects bring together his professional capacity and a personal history that does not fit neatly into it. His father had taught that learning law also required learning to read people. The son once dismissed the advice, but the journey makes it newly resonant. The spectacles can be read as a potential instrument of changed perception, not as proof that a moral conversion has taken place. The scene builds an unsettled character through material possessions; the professional's equipment and the father's reminder occupy the same bag without being reconciled by a single repentant declaration.

The Mirror of the First-Class Waiting Room

Using a special pass, Batuknath enters the first-class waiting area, but in the mirror his reflection remains outside. His body gains admission while his image is excluded. This visual division registers the distance between a formally privileged social position and inward insecurity. Someone accustomed to using permissions and procedural barriers against others finds the gesture of exclusion turned upon his own representation. The event belongs to the novel's magical register; it should not be converted into a statement that station regulations actually denied him entry. The

split reflection is a narrative evaluation of status and conscience. The familiar waiting room becomes an uncanny threshold at which documentary entitlement cannot guarantee a unified self.

The Moral Transformation of Station Names

As the train proceeds, Batuknath sees station boards bearing words such as "Date," "Adjournment," "Settlement" and "Silence." When he blinks, their ordinary geographical names return. This doubling makes the railway simultaneously a physical route and a map of professional memory. The narration stays close to Batuknath's perceptual state; the reader can recognise that the railway itself may continue unaffected. The metaphor of the crocodile of court dates, prominent in earlier chapters, has migrated onto railway signs. The significance is not that a supernatural authority has changed India's timetable but that the words by which Batuknath has exercised professional power now determine what he is capable of seeing, even beyond the courtroom.

The Unnamed Old Passenger as a Mirror Character

An elderly fellow traveller asks Batuknath whether he has learned to read names when the lawyer proudly says that he has studied law. The old man does not immediately disclose an extraordinary identity. His manner of questioning slowly exposes the architecture of Batuknath's self-description. This delay is important: an instant revelation that the passenger was a ghost would reduce the journey to a supernatural encounter, whereas the unanswered question requires the reader to assess what the stranger does. Polite interrogation confronts professional self-praise with an elementary human obligation. The old passenger's function is mirror-like, reflecting something the protagonist refuses to see; the suspense surrounding his identity sharpens rather than replaces that ethical encounter.

Crossing Above the River and Fearing to Look Below

As the train climbs onto a bridge, the old man asks Batuknath to look at names within the flowing water. The lawyer does not wish to look down. The visible bridge recalls the principal historical site of the novel's worker deaths. In one frame, the safety of a train carriage stands above the peril formerly experienced by those labouring beneath it. Batuknath's refusal to direct his eyes downward can be read as an act of avoidance, an unwillingness to confront the memory of labour and loss. But fear of looking is not the same as accepting legal or moral responsibility. The text provides a defensive response at this stage, not an articulated admission of guilt.

The Unseen Companion and the Absence of Confirmation

A ticket examiner sees Batuknath travelling alone and notices the empty place associated with the elderly passenger. This external viewpoint provides a separate hint concerning the stranger's nature. Is the old man a remembered figure, a projection of anxiety or a ghost who exists within the novel's magical world? The contrast between Batuknath's experience and the examiner's observation keeps the possibilities in tension. The identification of the passenger with the ghostly Burhbā subsequently becomes clearer, but the earlier moment retains its peculiar uncertainty. The scene is not simply evidence that Batuknath imagined every exchange. It exploits differing access to what characters can see, making the narration's distribution of knowledge itself a source of suspense.

A Kabaddi Circle Drawn on the Carriage Floor

The old man draws a circle and line with his stick on the floor of the railway carriage. Batuknath initially reads the design as a plan of a courtroom, but it becomes the field of kabaddi. A rural game's geometry enters an elite travelling compartment, joining legal procedure to a communal test of participation. The question is who remains inside when someone has won the game. Batuknath's formal definition of victory encounters a different notion of belonging, one developed in the children's changing kabaddi rules. The encounter does not collapse the distinction between a judicial ruling and a village game. Instead, it creates a dialogue between two formal systems that Batuknath had kept separate: the power to declare an outcome and the duty to recognise those affected.

The Failed Childhood Lesson in Reading Names

Batuknath remembers standing with his father on a court veranda beside a poor litigant. His father taught him to remember the man's name; winning or losing the case was a separate question. The flashback does not manufacture compassion out of nothing. It reveals a moral possibility that had once been offered to the character and subsequently neglected. This remembered lesson complicates a flat portrait of the villain without erasing the effects of the practices he later adopted. The narration offers an occasion for understanding, not compensation or reconciliation. Its importance lies in demonstrating that the lawyer's professional identity was formed amid competing teachings and that the forgotten one can return to challenge the apparently settled self.

Unexpected Knowledge through the Smell of Documents

The old man directs Batuknath's attention to the smell of the victory order. He senses perfume, air-conditioned rooms, leather, banknotes and foul water together. Law is ordinarily represented through clauses,

signatures and stamps; this novel repeatedly allows a document's social history to return through smell. The sensory sequence does not replace a legal reading, but opens an imaginative understanding of the lives surrounding the document. Nor does the mixture establish a particular bribe or a verified transaction. It is a scene of ethical discomfort in which the successful professional experiences the paper as carrying human and material conditions that its official wording does not acknowledge. Sensory perception becomes a critical supplement, not a forensic test.

The Question from a Boy Selling Makhana

At a small station, a boy selling boiled makhana asks whether Batuknath has won or lost, and why a victor should look so unhappy. The question is direct, lacking the elaborate interrogative method of the old passenger. Without professional rank or social authority, the boy reads the lawyer's bodily demeanour as an ethical contradiction. The episode gives a working child the role of interpreter. His words do not establish the legal disposition of Batuknath's case; they reveal the character's inability to inhabit the joy he believes victory should confer. By placing this observation alongside the stranger's probing questions, the author broadens the sources of moral insight beyond recognised institutions and credentials.

A Halt Beyond the Official Railway Map

At midnight, the train stops at a place absent from the timetable. The old man says that Batuknath's mind, rather than his body, has alighted. The strange halt marks the division between geographical travel and the inner encounter with judgment. The professional person may remain in the protected carriage even as the troubled consciousness arrives in the symbolic territory of Channa Grove. This is a new form of suspended time: the timetable and subjective duration no longer coincide. The scene should not be turned into a factual account of a newly discovered station. Its narrative purpose is to make the journey both locatable and unlocatable, so that movement through space becomes an examination of the assumptions carried within it.

“Conversation” versus “Reading”

Near the village, Batuknath says that he has come to talk. Burhbā answers that he has come to read. The difference between these verbs provides the chapter's culminating encounter. In a conversation of the kind Batuknath knows, one can set terms, negotiate, bargain and try to control the conclusion. Reading requires him first to attend to other people's names, injuries and histories. The asymmetry matters: he cannot begin with a proposed settlement until he recognises the persons whom his documents

have reduced to procedural categories. This is the chapter's most concentrated moral proposition. It does not certify that he has successfully learned the lesson. It places him at the beginning of a form of attention that his professional practice had repeatedly circumvented.

Overall Assessment: An Unresolved Encounter with the Self

Batuknath Hariharan's Journey constructs its moral crisis within a railway narrative, combining professional recollection, his father's counsel and the village's archival ethics. The examiner's empty seat, the divided mirror, altered station names, the makhana seller and the unnamed passenger produce several routes into the character's mind. Reaching the vicinity of the village does not equal repentance; Batuknath has not entirely relinquished the language of control. The chronology remains problematic because Chapter 23 already depicts a village visit. Whether the renewed journey is a deliberate circular movement or an inconsistency is not settled by the manuscript. Preserving that difficulty is essential to a review that remains faithful both to the artistic possibilities and to the source's actual limitations.

Critical Section 128 | Original Chapter 27 — Chandrapal Batra's Screen

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

A Stationary Body and a Travelling Mind

Batuknath takes the train, whereas Chandrapal decides against going to Garh Narikela. The contrast establishes different modes of response among the implicated figures. Remaining in a high-rise glass office, surrounded by modern screens and the authority of his professional identity, Chandrapal attempts to supervise resistance from a distance. Yet the image of a coconut leaf invades his display, diminishing the apparent protection supplied by geographical separation. The chapter does not describe a secret subterranean journey. It depicts an inward displacement in which the village enters a consciousness that refuses to enter the village. This reversal prepares a critique of power based on remote control: an office can remain physically secure while its occupant's understanding of safety begins to fragment.

Different Professional Identities and One Logic of Profit

Chandrapal presents himself variously as an advocate, consultant, compliance specialist and adviser to the digital entertainment industry. The narrative does not erase the distinctions between those professions. Its concern is how the vocabulary of legal conformity and financial self-interest may become mutually protective within a particular individual's practice. It would be unwarranted to treat all work in law, compliance or consulting as synonymous with criminal activity. The object of criticism is Chandrapal's specific use of professional authority to make arrangements driven by profit seem secure and legitimate. His multiplication of roles is thus a method of characterisation: the reader sees a single person's influence distributed across several apparently independent institutional languages.

The Coconut Leaf on the Screen

When Chandrapal types “Register of Names,” the screen flickers and a leaf appears; after he closes the display, a question is inscribed upon his face. The scene works through three levels of appearance, moving from digital characters to a botanical image and finally to the body of the person trying to erase it. Those suppressed by paperwork return within an electronic surface. Chandrapal seeks an ordinary account of a technical malfunction, but repeated appearances destabilise the explanation. Criticism must resist

turning this uncanny writing into verified hacking or a demonstrated result of cyber-forensic examination. It belongs to the novel's magical-realist language, in which a communal memory seems capable of addressing the agents of its suppression through the very equipment they control.

The Disappearing Message Reads Itself

A secret risk message associated with Raghav changes as Chandrapal composes or reads it, and Ujjwal's presence emerges on the screen. The ordinary hierarchy of editing is reversed. Rather than Chandrapal determining the text, a countertext of public memory appears to write through his intended words. The scene dramatises unauthorised writing in a supernatural register. It is not a signed legal record or an authenticated recovery of the complete digital conversation. Its force is relational: the individual whom the network wishes to treat as absent cannot be held absent within the fiction's ethical imagination. Ujjwal's name interrupts a channel designed to circulate instructions between those who manage other people's financial vulnerability.

Recalling the Examination Room in Meerut

The glass gives Chandrapal a view of the examination room in which he once studied law at Meerut. The recollection historicises his present authority: he was once an ordinary student before taking successive paths through professional practice, consultancy and the organisations that now surround him. Such memory is not a plea for exoneration. Its critical function is to trace how apparently indirect activities can become part of an exploitative system, even when they are presented as technical or lawful services. The character is neither reduced to innate wickedness nor relieved of responsibility by recalling his younger self. Instead, the retrospective image opens a question about the steps through which a learned skill becomes an instrument of concealment.

Foreign Percentages and an Indian Face

Chandrapal recognises a larger network behind Raghav: Lau, maritime commerce, banks and servers, all connected to distant profits. The foreign beneficiaries needed a credible domestic face, and he sees himself occupying that role. The passage makes power legible as a distribution of functions: direction and gain may occur far away, while local professional legitimacy gives transactions access to familiar institutions. Yet the character's inward account, the author's accusatory organisation of the plot and a formally established judicial finding are not identical kinds of knowledge. The chapter gives a sense of the network's structure without

laying out independent legal proof for every organisational relationship. The distinction is central to the criticism's credibility.

The Attraction of a Screen Empire

Looking from his balcony at thousands of illuminated windows, Chandrapal imagines the country's activities passing through screens: loans, love, travel tickets, medicines, employment and justice. His ambition is to profit by controlling connections among these domains. The passage should not be mistaken for the novel's final assessment of digital technology. Earlier chapters showed the same technology carrying warnings, educational material and readings of names. Chandrapal's vision belongs to his own profit-oriented focalisation. He sees social life as an opportunity for capture because his imagination approaches human conduct as a sequence of transactions. The contrast between the empire he imagines and the community's alternative uses of screens prevents the technological motif from becoming one-dimensional.

The Reader's Knowledge and the Wrongdoer's False Inference

On seeing the leaf, Chandrapal wants to believe that Gop, Soumya, Nishant and Ira have hacked his system. This interpretation reassures him: human adversaries can be served notices, threatened and subjected to economic pressure. The reader, however, has encountered ghostly interventions, self-writing leaves and the recurring names of the dead. The unequal distribution of information creates dramatic irony. Chandrapal prefers a technical enemy because that enemy fits his known instruments of control. But the narrative never validates his hypothesis as the cause of the apparitions. His proposed explanation reveals his psychological need to reduce an unruly ethical challenge to a familiar dispute over technical access.

The Return of Erased Messages in Print

A paper printout appears to contain messages that Raghav had deleted. Chandrapal had treated the transience of screen-based communication as an advantage of his operation. The return of writing on paper confronts that assumption with a different conception of permanence, drawn from the village's preservation of names. In formal terms, the narrative changes the medium of the trace: the digital “delete” is answered by the old archive's refusal to forget. The event must not be advertised as proof of a specific data-recovery technique. Its supernatural force is the suggestion that a social history cannot simply be made nonexistent by a participant's assertion that the electronic trace has vanished.

A Sequence of Questions

Chandrapal's screen asks who benefited from the commission attached to the first win, whose accounts were used, why an account continued after a death and who was responsible for digital threats. The questions gather events scattered across earlier chapters into the consciousness of a figure implicated in the network. In particular, the possibility of transactions continuing in a dead youth's name becomes a new source of fear. This internal interrogation provides narrative convergence, not a judicial declaration that every account and account holder has been proved criminal. Its accusatory questions have literary force because they reassemble relations that Chandrapal's professional classifications kept apart: income, coercion, death, paperwork and the use of personal identity.

Veins in the Broken Screen

Chandrapal slams his laptop down. Cracks spread through the glass like the veins of a coconut leaf, interchanging imagery from paper, vegetation and electronic technology. A damaged device appears to retain signs of life and writing. The defeat pictured here does not follow simply from the destruction of expensive equipment. It follows from the protagonist's discovery that destroying the equipment cannot expel the names that trouble him. His anger becomes a bodily action revealing the failure of control. The magical transformation remains symbolic rather than a scientific account of what the broken display contains, but its sensory detail gives the metaphor a force absent from an abstract declaration that truth survives.

The Incomplete Education of the Law Degree

Batra turns around the framed diploma from Meerut. The glass seems to say that he has not completed his education in reading names. The university credential is set against an ethical form of literacy. The opposition can become too explicit, even didactic, but the character's personal unease keeps it connected to experience. Nothing in the episode establishes that legal scholarship is inherently corrupt. The criticism concerns Chandrapal's use of that knowledge to compress complex lives into administratively convenient categories. His degree records an acquired qualification; the newly visible question concerns a different competence, one he cannot obtain retroactively through a frame or professional title.

Entering the Village without Travelling There

At the close, Chandrapal's body remains in the city's glass enclosure, while his mind is caught in the veins of the leaf and the cracks of the screen, imaginatively reaching Channa Grove. His remote psychological passage

reverses Batuknath's physical journey in Chapter 26. The village has become more than a location on a map: it is the point from which a community's memory penetrates the inner arrangements of distant authority. The screen, previously a symbol of Chandrapal's reach, now becomes a means of his involuntary connection with people he had treated as manageable entries. This does not give the villagers legal control of his office. It alters the narrative direction of attention.

Critical Assessment: The Reversal of Ownership over the Screen

The chapter's principal achievement is to transform the very medium on which the wrongdoer relies for control into a medium of resistance. Professional identities, personal memory, foreign relationships, deleted messages and questions concerning a dead user's accounts combine into Chandrapal's layered crisis. Its weakness is that the repeated supernatural appearance of the leaf has begun to become predictable. His eagerness to attribute the phenomenon to hacking nevertheless distinguishes his psychology from that of the other implicated figures. He cannot escape the village's ethical questions by declining to visit it. The narrative makes his screen answerable to memory without pretending that an uncanny apparition is the same thing as a judicially proven offence.

Critical Section 129 | Original Chapter 28 — Raghav Signal's Silence

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Story of a Specialist in the Absence of Speech

Raghav "Signal" Somani is introduced through his efforts to avoid a lasting record of speech. He writes, deletes and rewrites messages because recorded words might become testimony. His technical skill cannot be separated from the fear shaping his private conduct. This creates the chapter's governing irony: a person who distributes threats delivered in the voices of false police officers is himself afraid of the vulnerability created by an audible voice. The silence of the title is not innocent reserve. It is a designed system for making traces disappear. The chapter begins its study of the intermediary criminal by exposing how his method of controlling others has formed an unstable condition of personal existence.

A Leaf Growing inside the Clean Screen

Raghav repeatedly cleans devices, removes old communications and separates identifying information. Yet a green leaf appears at the edge of his screen. This magical intrusion questions his assumption that disciplined technical management can guarantee the disappearance of all traces. The passage does not provide a repeatable cyber technique, an account of forensic success or evidence of a particular unauthorised login. The leaf is the same image of communal remembrance that occupied the living game field in Chapter 24. Its appearance in an isolated operating room makes the fantasy of perfect erasure impossible within the story's symbolic order. Its meaning is ethical and literary, not a substitute for technical documentation.

Human Beings inside Geographical Codes

A list in a metal cupboard connects numbers with Hong Kong, Macau, Dubai, Kathmandu, Guwahati, Patna, Meerut and Delhi. Raghav has treated such places principally as routes for money. The chapter recovers the people and families obscured by this geographical coding. A payment route does not, by itself, provide a complete account of a crime; the difficulty lies in recognising the unstable social positions of those through whose names and accounts money passes. The narrator translates the scale of international finance back into local human relations. The result is not an attempt to collapse the world into one village but a demand to

distinguish the abstract pathway of a transfer from the differing intentions and knowledge of the people involved.

Unemployment as Narrative Material

Raghav's recruitment activities extend to student hostels, coaching streets, tea stalls, private colleges and places occupied by migrant workers. Small commissions appeal to people whose economic positions leave them vulnerable. The novel does not equate poverty with an inclination towards crime. Financial weakness is the condition under which an unequal proposal can be accepted without full understanding. The organiser's intention and a young account holder's knowledge therefore require different descriptions. Munna Paswan's earlier story becomes more intelligible when set beside this wider system of recruitment. To call all participants equally culpable would erase the structural differences the chapter is attempting to bring into view.

The Structural Noise of "Account Closed"

A message of only two words—"Account closed"—arrives on Raghav's telephone. Behind the brevity lies the power of the larger profit centre to abandon an intermediary when he has ceased to be useful. The account is not merely an electronic channel for cash; in this language, it determines the apparent life of a business relationship. Raghav experiences a version of the precariousness he has imposed upon vulnerable account holders. His previously secure position becomes commercially disposable. The episode does not thereby make him an innocent victim of the same conduct. It provides an internal reversal that exposes the network's willingness to erase its own agents as casually as it exploits those recruited from outside.

The Return of an Old Paper Notebook

After relying on technology for nearly every operation, Raghav opens a paper notebook. The physical object seems to offer relief from the digital domain, yet it too contains traces of names. Paper is not treated by the novel as invariably pure or corrupt. The same material can preserve coded criminal activity or support Ba's public memorial. Its ethical significance depends upon use. Raghav's notebook belongs to the history of his attempts to protect himself; the village's leaves belong to a practice of keeping persons publicly recognisable. The juxtaposition demonstrates that the conflict between remembrance and erasure is not a simple contest between old and new media, but between different relations to the human beings named within them.

Arunesh Kumar's Name as a Door into Memory

Raghav recalls an early arrangement involving a commission of five thousand, a student's account, later legal trouble and damage to the student's family. Arunesh Kumar's name becomes a door into this recollection. When one name is written, the unfinished line of another appears, suggesting that settling the account of one person does not resolve the histories of all others touched by the network. The source does not provide the full independent investigative record of every consequence suffered by the student. The form and limits of Raghav's recollection must be kept distinct from the events it evokes. The episode is powerful because it prevents guilt from being contained within a single anecdote of an early mistake.

An Echo of His Father's Hardware Shop

Raghav remembers his father, a hardware shop, iron nails and a ledger recording credit. His father had taught the importance of writing names correctly, while the son gradually learned to see accounts rather than people when money could be made. This resembles the lesson Batuknath received from his own father about remembering a poor litigant's name. Two implicated characters thus possess different biographies yet have neglected related early warnings. The parallel can seem unusually systematic, as if the narrative were arranging every father's advice around its central motif. Nevertheless, it extends the question of record-keeping into domestic memory, where even a modest ledger may preserve an ethic absent from the later financial network.

The Difference between a Donation and an Account

Raghav begins to think that giving a donation would be easier than providing a complete account. A donor can remain in control of a gift, whereas an honest accounting requires the injured person's name, the event, responsibility and the right to contradict the giver's version. This is a major extension of the novel's critique of the language of accounts. Philanthropy cannot automatically stand in for an acknowledgement of harm. Yet the text has not settled whether Raghav's recognition signals genuine reform or a more sophisticated defensive manoeuvre. An inward thought is narratively significant because it opens a possibility; its moral meaning can only be tested by what the character subsequently does with that recognition.

The Small Experiment of Sleeping without the Phone

For the first time, Raghav places his phone away from his pillow. The action is ordinary, but it briefly interrupts a life structured around continuous messaging. Sleep does not come immediately. Channa Grove is

present as a waking thought rather than simply as a dream. The episode gives the narrative an opportunity to move beyond automatic supernatural punishment into the possibility of deliberate personal discipline. Removing a device, however, does not discharge financial responsibilities or undo an exploitative operation. The small alteration in habit may matter as an initial break in dependence, but it remains incomparably less than the acts of disclosure, reparation or accountability that the larger story would require.

A Different Motive for "Not Going"

Raghav decides that he will not travel to Garh Narikela. Chandrapal also wishes to stay away, but their motives differ. Chandrapal wants to defeat resistance from a distance; Raghav wants to avoid recognition and the oppressive return of remembered names. Identical choices of movement can arise from different psychological needs. The distinction is essential if the group of implicated characters is not to become a single interchangeable antagonist. Their business interests may be connected, but fear takes a specific form in each consciousness. The narrator identifies these differences without allowing either decision to be read as a sufficient explanation of innocence, repentance or future conduct.

The "Imprint" of a Deleted Voice

The image of Raghav's deleted message reappearing on paper or in memory recurs throughout the chapter. In formal terms, it is a symbolic copy preserved against the ambition of digital forgetting. If every supernatural imprint were assumed to be original data authenticated for legal proceedings, the novel's own concern with verification would disappear. The literary meaning is the rupture of a criminal's imagined invisibility. Announcing that a message no longer exists is not enough to remove the human history it helped produce. A trace remains within the narrative's ethical imagination even when no fully specified technical mechanism is narrated. The image therefore speaks to responsibility without replacing documentary investigation.

The Changing Nature of Silence

At the beginning, Raghav's silence is an operational rule for avoiding evidence. By the end, it includes sleepless questioning and the discomfort of recognising an old name. These two silences should not be conflated into an accomplished moral development. A person may be troubled by an inward question and still be far from answering it publicly. The narrative leaves Raghav caught between acknowledgement, fear and the possibility of flight. This restraint distinguishes psychological disturbance from redemption. Silence is transformed in its felt quality but not yet in its

social consequence. Whether it can become truthful speech remains an issue for the unwritten continuation of his character's actions.

Critical Conclusion

Raghav Signal's Silence gains depth by investigating the private instability of a criminal intermediary whose system depends upon not leaving audible traces. Geographical codes, the father's ledger, Arunesh Kumar's name, the message "Account closed" and the act of putting aside a telephone give the character several overlapping histories. The recurrent magical leaf risks becoming a repetitive narrative mechanism, sometimes more conspicuous than the evolution of his consciousness. Yet the unfinished line that appears after one name has been written is especially effective. It dramatises a network's responsibility as something incapable of being exhausted by one conveniently closed account. Raghav's silence changes, but the chapter does not announce either confession or absolution.

Critical Section 130 | Original Chapter 29 — Lau Kin-Hung's Dream

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

A Commercial Identity in Three Letters

Lau Kin-Hung avoids making his full name publicly prominent; in the obscured financial world he operates as "L.K.H." The practice is linked in the narrative to a calculated fear of identification and arrest. An important contrast follows. Villagers labour to restore names deliberately removed from records, while the figure at the centre of profit conceals his own. The ethical value of naming thus depends upon circumstance: a suppressed worker seeks recognition; an exploiting organiser seeks protection through anonymity. Initials do not by themselves establish criminal guilt, and no such generalisation is warranted. Their significance emerges from Lau's particular position within the fiction, where profit and the refusal to be personally answerable are closely associated.

The Glass Cave: The Illusion of Inside and Outside

Lau's glass residence beside the sea presents ships outside and screens within as parts of a single view. Outside is water, inside percentages; outside, vessels, inside, payments. This spatial arrangement prepares the chapter's magical invasion by water. The dwelling embodies security, wealth and separation. Yet seeing the sea through glass is not the same as understanding the human history of its routes. Lau perceives streams of money without attending to the labourers and victims whose lives lie behind their movement. The carefully constructed interior therefore creates an ironic vulnerability: its transparency in a visual sense coexists with profound opacity in human terms, leaving the occupant protected from contact but exposed to his own interpretive limits.

The Mixed Smell of Death in Seawater

During the dream, water enters Lau's glass building. He enumerates insurance, pumps, emergency exits and helicopters—the devices through which wealth anticipates danger. But this is not ordinary seawater. It bears the mixed smells of medicine, cement, mobile telephones and damp banknotes. The sensory transformation brings into the global movement of funds the insecurities of very different communities. Each protective facility answers a calculable financial risk; the question posed by lost human lives resists that logic. The scene is not the narration of an actual Hong Kong flood. It is a collapse within Lau's private dream of the

assumptions that make his resources seem adequate to every danger. The mixture of smells gives the distant suffering a disquieting bodily immediacy.

Testimony on One Telephone after Another

Telephones float towards Lau across the dream water. Ujjwal, Sarayu, people subjected to false arrest threats and other unnamed victims appear with their questions. The telephone, earlier a medium of predatory communication, becomes an audible channel for injured people. In Chapter 8, threatening calls helped isolate Ujjwal; here the same kind of screen requires Lau to occupy the position of someone who must answer. This inversion confirms that the novel does not assign a fixed moral identity to a technological object. It can carry coercion or testimony depending on the relations within which it operates. The devices are dream images, however, not verified recordings newly submitted to an investigative body.

The Recurrent Dispute over the Rope Mark on Ujjwal's Neck

Lau dreams of Ujjwal with a blue rope mark on his neck. Chapter 16 also describes Ujjwal as found hanging from a fan, whereas Chapter 8 narrated a slipper found beside the Balan and a body recovered from water the following morning. The criticism has already identified these divergent accounts. The fact that the latest scene occurs in a dream allows for the possibility of symbolic reconfiguration, but the novel does not explicitly reconcile all three depictions. A textual inconsistency remains a valid alternative reading. It would be improper to manufacture a single authoritative sequence of Ujjwal's final hours. The distinctions between the initial narrated event, the later ghost's account and Lau's dream must be preserved, even when their images are emotionally interconnected.

Multiple Crocodiles and the Machinery of Profit

Black crocodiles appear in the dream with different institutional attributes: one chews telephones, another bears a court seal, another has Harvard's light in its eyes, and another contains signs of medical equipment and digital payments. The separate lines of exploitation explored in earlier chapters acquire various forms of one folk-animal metaphor. The crocodile has moved far beyond its literal existence as a river creature, becoming an emblem of the institutional means by which people are consumed. Yet this expansive metaphor also carries a critical risk. If every form of danger is called a crocodile, its distinctive social causes may become indistinct. The characters' different experiences are necessary to give the general symbol discriminating force.

Counting as a Defence

Surrounded by crocodiles, Lau refuses at first to admit fear and begins to count. Numbers are the language of his business, the means by which he expects uncertainty to become manageable. But the names sounding from the water cannot be completely absorbed into a numerical account. The opposition does not condemn counting as such: throughout the novel, the recovery of excluded names also requires careful enumeration. Rather, the criticism concerns the insufficiency of an accounting practice that translates death and exploitation exclusively into profit. Lau's defensive habit exposes the distance between the usefulness of calculation and its failure as a complete description of human life. His inability to stop counting is a sign of diminished imaginative capacity.

Rows of Money Beneath the Speech

The dream shifts to Harvard. Broome speaks of dignity and development while financial sums and percentages appear beneath those terms on Lau's tablet. This is the technique of a double text: the public statement of ethical principle and the private arithmetic of profit are made visible at once. Rather than supplying an ordinary indictment, the writer edits two competing inscriptions into one scene. The source does not provide independently corroborated account records for every particular amount implied by the dream. Their role is to make the speaker's possible duplicity legible in Lau's frightened perception. The dream rewrites an earlier speech through the consciousness of the person who treats such performances as part of a financial landscape.

The Village Pipal in Broome's Auditorium

Water drips from the auditorium ceiling in Lau's imagination, and a pipal tree grows at its centre with Burhbā seated upon a branch. A prestigious educational venue becomes a version of the village's folk court. Applause turns into the sound of a splash. Ira is not on the principal stage; she stands outside with the children engaged in reading names. This is a dream-based rewriting of the arrangement in Chapter 22, not the assertion that another university ceremony has actually taken place. Its function is to bring institutional prestige into the narrative jurisdiction of remembered lives. The distinctions between the original event, the second lecture and this oneiric adaptation must remain visible.

The Unachieved Normality after Waking

Awakening, Lau calls the security department, the financial department and the India operation. He is told that everything is normal, yet the message from India is penetrated by echoes of the village's register of names. The contradiction between outward order and inward fear gives

the scene its tension. Lau's financial organisation has not demonstrably collapsed. What has changed is his experience of its apparent invulnerability. The chapter does not represent waking anxiety as conclusive repentance. Indeed, his first action is to confirm operational control, not to contact victims or disclose wrongdoing. The insistence on "normal" conditions exposes the gap between the stability of an organisation's procedures and the ethical significance of what those procedures conceal.

Mei Lan's Independent Observation

Lau's chief assistant, Mei Lan, reports broken contact with Raghav, Batra's anxiety about verification and news of Hariharan's village journey. She also observes that efforts to find names in the village are increasing. Her contribution is distinct from Lau's dream. She offers information about organisational behaviour from another position within the operation. To treat her solely as a decorative secretary would overlook this shift of perspective. The text gives her a role in conveying concrete contextual signs against which the principal character's fears can be situated. Her independent decision-making authority remains limited, however. The narration does not give her the same degree of control over operations or knowledge of all their consequences that Lau assumes for himself.

The Arrival of a Green Leaf on the Desk

A green coconut leaf is found on Lau's desk, although it was not present during the dream. Its veins resemble lines of bank transfers; its marks look like names in Devanagari. Lau cannot read the script, yet "Garh Narikela" seems to arise within him. The object's origin remains unexplained. It creates a magical passage between languages and locations, permitting an unfamiliar village memory to interrupt a system premised on distant profit. It would be unfounded to claim that a courier delivered the leaf or that its marks encode an independently recoverable banking database. Its narrative work is symbolic, but that does not make the scene insignificant: it turns the distant community into something the principal beneficiary cannot simply keep beyond his desk.

The Cold Cruelty of Three Financial Orders

Lau ends by ordering Raghav's access terminated, Batra's payments stopped and Hariharan's expenses separated. The reaction is decisive in one respect: after experiencing fear, he chooses self-protection through the severing of associates rather than an ethical transformation. The author does not convert him into a philanthropist, a remorseful penitent or a person already cleared of responsibility. The orders illustrate the inner distrust of a network in which relationships remain contingent upon usefulness. Their

eventual legal or operational outcomes are not narrated here. The distinction between issuing an instruction and establishing what actually happened afterwards must be preserved. The character's actions after waking are the best evidence of the limits of his apparent self-questioning.

Overall Assessment: The Dream That Continues Within

Lau Kin-Hung's Dream carries the overarching crocodile imagery from the river to a glass building by the sea. Telephones that testify, different crocodile figures, the double text at Harvard, Mei Lan's reports and the pulse of a green leaf build a multi-layered relationship between dream and waking. The principal artistic risk is that the dream sometimes becomes an overly orderly device for presenting questions and defeating each of Lau's defences in sequence. Yet his cold financial orders restore an important distinction between fear and remorse. The discordant descriptions of Ujjwal's death are also repeated, making source-faithful acknowledgement of ambiguity indispensable. The dream unsettles a system's imagined immunity without narrating its definitive dismantling.

Critical Section 131 | Original Chapter 30 — The Court within the Rogues

An independent narratological criticism based on the original Maithili text

The Multiplication of Inner Hearings from an External Court

Chapter 30 redistributes Channa Grove's collective supernatural court into the separate minds of the implicated figures. There are no formal summonses, official robes or courthouse doors; each consciousness becomes the scene of its own hearing. Batuknath, Chandrapal, Raghav, Lau and Edward Broome are joined through parallel editing across one night. This arrangement creates an inward literary counterpart to public punishment, not a substitute for it. The five figures retain their outward freedom while confronting the names they have attempted to suppress. The narrative movement is from a single gathering to several isolated consciousnesses, making memory an intrusive witness at precisely those points where external authority continues to appear secure.

The Numerical Tension between "Five" and "Four Cities"

The opening announces the minds of five wrongdoers, initially describes "three people in three cities" before introducing Lau overseas, and eventually speaks of "four cities" even though five separate inner hearings are presented. The discrepancy does not require the invention of a missing sixth person or an unmentioned geographical arrangement. It indicates that the numerical language of the spatial montage is not entirely consistent. Criticism must state this openly without destroying the scene's emotional parallelism. The five experiences are present; their coordination by count and location is less precise. The distinction exemplifies a larger requirement of reading the novel: its ambitious multi-site composition may be effective in theme and imagery while still exhibiting imperfect bookkeeping at the level of explicit numbers.

"Nand" Emerging from the Middle of Batuknath's Order

Batuknath reads his order declaring the petition dismissed on procedural grounds. From within the word for dismissal emerge the names Nand, Sarayu and Ujjwal. This is a visual transgression of legal language: the persons whom procedure sought to remove return within the letters of removal itself. Batuknath seeks the rigidity of a settled legal document, but its textual surface seems to crumble into remembered human presence. The chronology remains unresolved between the interim protective order in Chapter 15 and the later description of dismissal. The uncanny writing

does not supply the missing legal sequence. Its function is to challenge the character's confidence that a procedural conclusion can exhaust the lives which gave rise to the dispute.

The Child as Judge

In Batuknath's study, a child wearing shorts places a pipal leaf upon the desk. Rather than being established as an identifiable living visitor, the child appears as a counter-memory of Batuknath's own childhood. No judicial hammer is struck. The small sound of the leaf touching the surface begins the hearing. This substitution of childhood for judge is formally striking: it carries the character back before the sophistication of his professional evasions to an earlier moral education. The return of that education does not erase his present responsibility. The scene asks whether the lawyer can still recognise the instruction to read another person's name that he received before learning to manage cases as procedures.

Chandrapal's Screen and the "Reconciliation of Accounts"

Chandrapal sees names, passbooks and Ujjwal's threatening messages on his screen. Within the display, a courtroom takes shape without a judge: an empty chair, a torn passbook and the character's own defensive speech. The assertion of consent is challenged by the book's question about what the account holder actually understood. The object speaks in a way that stands in for suppressed testimony. In literary terms, an account book becomes a critic of the social relation it once abstracted into numbers. The invented inner cross-examination, however, is not the same as an authorised judicial review of evidence. Its questions reveal the limits of financial and contractual language without conclusively determining every individual's legal responsibility.

The Adviser Who Shows the Way into a Pit

Chandrapal's inner court reverses the meaning of "adviser": someone supposedly showing the right path has in fact guided others towards a pit. This redefinition exposes a distance between professional designation and actual function. Readers can trace it back through the contracts in Chapter 9, the financial routes in Chapter 11 and Chandrapal's screen in Chapter 27. A word whose ordinary meaning implies assistance becomes unstable through the actions of its user. The internal challenge is not a complete personal confession, but it does undermine the foundation of professional prestige. The scene turns the character's own vocabulary into an instrument of criticism, making the language of consultation answerable to those who were harmed by the advice.

Leaves Bearing Raghav's Unfinished Messages

Leaves fall through Raghav's closed room. They carry fragments about accounts, impersonated threats, women's photographs and percentages. These are signs of different exploitative operations, not complete transcripts of every criminal exchange. Raghav tries to burn the leaves, but they do not ignite. Their resistance challenges natural expectation within the magical register, expressing the collective wish that traces of wrongdoing not be destroyed. As practical evidence, fragments would still require verification and contextual reconstruction. Their narrative power resides in a concentrated fear that even deliberately unfinished sentences and suppressed documents might return to confront the person who controlled their circulation. The unburnable leaf is the folk archive's answer to his system of deletion.

An Elderly Woman's Accusation through the Telephone

An elderly woman appears in Raghav's inner mirror and asks how he slept after making someone hear a false message from the police. The question reverses his chosen relation to sound. A man who avoided leaving his own voice on record must now listen to the remembered voice of someone frightened by the operation. This is not evidence of completed empathy. He may be listening out of terror rather than solidarity. Nevertheless, the encounter offers the possibility of conscience through forced attention. It connects the personal disturbance of an intermediary to the village's practical campaign against fraud, where listening to another person's fear became the basis of help and education.

Lau's Judgment through Bowls and Objects

In Lau's glass residence, bowls appear on a plain table, containing coins, medicine, a drop of blood and broken pieces of mobile-phone glass. The objects compress the network's different economic fields into a sensory collection of things. Lau prefers the distance implied by calling himself merely a designer of systems. His inner court replaces the question of who personally moved a hand with that of who took a share. The shift reconstructs accountability in metaphorical form. It is not a final legal determination of joint responsibility. The narrative refuses to let an abstract business architecture disown the physical vulnerability associated with its revenues, but it expresses the refusal through an imagined hearing rather than a settled evidentiary process.

The Discomfort of Broome's Civilised Hearing

Edward Broome's inner court consists of quiet wooden panels, dim light and soundproof walls. In the judge's place sits the applause that ordinarily greets his speeches. This is among the chapter's most effective formal

choices: external acclaim returns as the sound that demands an answer. Polished language, international ethical conferences and the attractive surfaces of publicity become sources of inward accusation. The controlled acoustic environment emphasises that the character cannot fully isolate his conscience by controlling what his audience hears. Yet this remains a literary vision of Broome's anxiety. It does not establish a formal admission of wrongdoing by a university, an employer or Broome himself.

The Multiplication of One Invisible Empty Chair

An empty chair appears across all five inner hearings. Its possible occupants are people whom the characters cannot now find waiting on the courthouse steps: the dead who were not named and the living opponents occupied with other forms of work. The image therefore has a double function. It registers an absence produced by suppression, and also the withdrawal of a community from the ritual of perpetual dependence upon its procedural adversaries. The performance of victory had required defeated people to remain visibly awaiting a reply. Their different activities disturb that relation. Emptiness does not mean the absence of a case; it becomes the sign of a changed balance between institutional waiting and social initiative.

The Sentence "Not Punishment, but Waiting"

At the end, the wrongdoers leave their inner hearings without a formal sentence. What they receive is waiting. This reverses the temporal arrangement developed in The Grief of Victory and The Empty Court. Court dates once imposed a burdensome interval on the injured, while now those implicated in harm must wait for a community's next response. The change is a psychological and narrative reorganisation of time, not a judicial decree that ordinary obligations have been fulfilled. The text itself acknowledges the absence of a legal verdict from these inward proceedings. Waiting becomes an ethically charged form of suspense, keeping the possibility of future responsibility open while refusing to call mental discomfort an adequate punishment.

The Labour of the Living versus the Wrongdoers' Sleeplessness

While the implicated figures spend the night confronting their inner courts, children in the village clean the school in the morning. The contrast juxtaposes supernatural fear with ordinary physical work. Channa Grove's public life no longer depends solely on judgment pronounced by ghosts. Cleaning, translation, teaching and the continued reading of names embody its living response. The worth of the community's undertaking is expressed in activities that protect others, not in the degree of torment experienced by its opponents. This scene prevents the novel's

critique from becoming wholly absorbed by the psychological lives of its antagonists. The apparently modest task of preparing a learning space is offered as an active counterpart to their grand nocturnal disturbances.

Overall Assessment: Simultaneous Inner Narration

The Court within the Rogues divides the moral psychology of its antagonists into several echoes of the common folk court. Childhood, a passbook, leaves, bowls and applause represent five different professional ways of evading responsibility, now subjected to inward questioning. The parallel editing is the chapter's principal achievement. Its limitation is that each symbol moves the character towards a broadly similar kind of accusation, reducing some of the uncertainty that would distinguish one consciousness from another. The discrepancy in the opening counts and geographical description is another compositional weakness. Even so, the final reversal from imposed delay to the wrongdoers' own waiting reinforces the novel's long-standing structure. Its conclusion remains provisional: public action continues, while private fear is not yet either repentance or justice.

Critical Section 132 | Original Chapter 31 — The Work of the Defeated

Not a Slogan, but the Work of Dawn

At the opening of Chapter 31, those described as the “defeated” neither burn effigies, fashion black flags nor immediately proclaim another appeal. They divide the day's work at dawn. This narrative choice replaces the darkness of the antagonists' inward struggles in the preceding four chapters with the light of ordinary activity. The opposition between judicial victory and defeat continues to organise the plot, but the principal arena of social consequences has moved to the school, translation, collective pledges and the archive. “Defeat” is thereby redefined against the community's capacity for action. Instead of merely announcing resistance to an adversary, the characters produce work with purposes that do not depend upon being watched by the adversary. The distribution of tasks is an event in its own right, not an appendix to a failed court case.

Ananya's Kabaddi without a Dividing Line

Ananya draws a new circular ground but leaves out the line marking exclusion. Anyone who loses a turn is not expelled from the game; that player receives another task. The change fundamentally transforms the competitive rules of earlier kabaddi episodes. The courage of crossing a boundary becomes education in responsibility beyond the game. Yet the analogy between rules of play and actual inequalities of power must not be made absolute. Erasing the line on the ground does not erase all the social divisions of a village. The new rule opens a possibility rather than demonstrating that reform has already been accomplished. By allowing a losing player to continue contributing, the scene makes a small but significant distinction between losing a contest and losing the right to participate in collective life.

Devika's Broken Telephone

Devika carries Ujjwal's broken telephone, rather than his photograph, towards the school. The choice is an important sign of mourning. The dead young man's face remains within intimate personal memory; the damaged device becomes material through which others may understand the experience of deception. The telephone is no longer simply an instrument of fear but a tangible example for public caution. Nevertheless, the ethical use of a dead person's device requires the question of how such teaching can proceed without disclosing every private detail preserved inside it. The episode's purpose is not unlimited exposure of digital records. Devika seeks to draw living people out of the isolation created by threats.

The object allows her private grief to acquire a social use without thereby extinguishing its private significance.

Nishant's Financial Diagram in the People's Language

Nishant, who can read the structures of international payment networks, explains the danger of allowing another person to use one's account through a local image: it is like renting out one's shadow. This metaphor makes an unfamiliar financial arrangement comprehensible to the audience, without substituting for a complete examination of transactions. Munna Paswan's presence is especially significant. A person who opened an account ceases to be merely a member of the general category of anonymous account holders and acquires an emotional and social place among the listeners. The figure of the rented shadow connects digital arrangements to a familiar sense of bodily identity. It also illustrates the limits of metaphor: the circumstances of each account holder, including what was known and freely chosen, still require independent attention.

Munna's Place in the Front Row

Devika brings Munna forward from the back, where he has been sitting in embarrassment. Her assertion that a person caught in a scheme should be heard as a witness before being branded guilty raises the problem of radically unequal information. Here communal listening restores a person's claim to his name. Yet being heard as a "witness" is not equivalent to formal acquittal. Degrees of inducement, economic necessity, knowledge and independent choice must remain distinguishable if the narrative is to maintain its ethical precision. Munna is neither expelled from the community's care nor given a fictional judicial certificate of innocence. The physical act of moving him to the front expresses a change in who is permitted to speak, not a completed determination of legal responsibility.

Soumya's Translation of Official Language

Soumya renders "procedural delay" into the life it conceals: the father has died, the son has grown old, and yet the court dates keep arriving. The bilingual scene is among the novel's most effective reflections on language. Within a dry technical expression, an entire human lifetime becomes visible. Translation is not merely the selection of dictionary equivalents; it is a representation of what legal time means for those compelled to inhabit it. At the same time, the precise sense of a statutory provision should not disappear into an evocative explanation. Keeping the technical term alongside its meaning in the people's language would permit both clarity and fidelity. Soumya's work exposes the difference between understanding

official vocabulary and understanding the social duration that vocabulary can obscure.

Meera and the Public Limits of Privacy

Meera arrives late, wearing white, and states the collective pledge in her own terms: love must not become a weapon, the privacy of the body must not become a market, and profit extracted from fear must cease. Some women and young men in the gathering lower their eyes. Meera does not respond by accusing or publicly shaming them. That restraint prevents an assertion rooted in personal experience from turning into an indiscriminate denunciation of everyone listening. Consent, dignity and the capacity to speak for oneself acquire further meaning in relation to Chapters 10 and 21. Meera speaks publicly about the principles at stake while retaining her authority over the boundaries of her own intimate history. Public resistance and personal privacy are not contradictory obligations.

A Shared Pledge to Protect Life

Devika, Meera, Soumya, Ananya and others pledge not to make privacy into a spectacle, to recognise fraud and speak names, and to stand beside a person approaching collapse. Because these declarations are linked to the day's actual division of labour, they do not remain simply ceremonial. The pledge rests not upon a religious or judicial text but upon reciprocal obligations. Its clear repetition of the earlier "Pledge of Privacy" reinforces the narrator's abiding social principle. Yet thematic recurrence also carries a stylistic risk: when the same rule is proclaimed repeatedly, the density of new events may diminish. The chapter's distinctive contribution is that the words accompany specific acts of teaching, translation and inclusion. Their social significance will ultimately depend on conduct, not repeated utterance.

Ira's International Extension of the Leaf Reading

Ira has not returned abroad, yet she takes the reading of names into a distant educational gathering. A meeting of Indian, African, Latin American and other Asian students takes shape under the designation "leaf reading." Rather than make emphatic accusations from an international platform, Ira allows the names of workers to be heard. Structurally, the village's local memory becomes the basis of instruction across communities. Still, the experiences of students from different countries are not developed in independent depth. This is the declaration of a widening horizon, not the completed construction of a multinational ensemble of characters. The narrative significance lies in the proposed

circulation of testimony while retaining the difference between a common ethical concern and the distinct histories of the participants.

From Gop's Table to Human Relationships

Gop asks that data be explained in ordinary language. Beside columns for name and payment, he proposes entries for home, children and dreams; when a dream is unknown, the space should remain blank. This is a particularly meaningful rule of narrative writing. An economic table becomes an account of relationships intelligible to ordinary people, while the prohibition against filling unknown spaces preserves the integrity of the record. A blank communicates an absence of evidence. If it is supplied with imagined details, the community archive loses credibility. The injunction is as important to the critical reading as to the fictional archive: documents may invite interpretation, but unanswered questions must not silently be converted into invented biographies. Gop's table is humane precisely because it refuses the pretence of omniscience.

The Child's New Question about "Justice"

Aruni remains caught between defeat in formal litigation, the victory imagined in Channa Grove and the persistent questioning of living children. Ba says that a decision is made on paper, whereas justice takes shape in people's conduct. The sentence is not a complete repudiation of institutional judgments. It emphasises a new form of responsibility emerging from the community's autonomous work. Symbolically completed justice and the indispensable work of legal investigation must remain separate. The child's question provides the narrative with continuing moral energy because it refuses to treat any single declaration as the last word. It also connects an old theme—the limitations of the written order—with the newly practical question of what people can do together the following morning.

How Knowledge Affects the Criminal Business

Chandrapal hears that young people in three villages have avoided being trapped; Lau is troubled by declining conversion; Raghav worries about the failure to find new victims. These short reports offer glimpses of the practical consequences of the educational work. Yet its unexpectedly wide influence sometimes appears with remarkable speed. The establishment of one local school does not demonstrate the complete regional extinction of a vast financial network. The specific incidents should be read as examples of possible effects, not exhaustive numerical evidence. The alternating scenes nevertheless establish a meaningful conflict: instruction turns attention towards the questions a prospective victim can ask before becoming dependent upon a fraudulent system. The antagonists encounter

unfamiliar friction, but their operations have not been shown to have ended.

New Records from Household Chests

Villagers begin asking one another which names have survived in their houses and which still need to be written down. Chests are opened; letters, photographs, wage slips, medical receipts and school certificates emerge. This is the replication, household by household, of Nand's early documentary undertaking. Every family becomes a potential co-author of memory. The reliability of the archive is therefore an even more pressing question. Original objects, relatives' recollections, uncertainties and incomplete dates should be preserved with their differences marked. Otherwise communal enthusiasm might give rise to an illusion of infallible history. The scene's achievement is not that all gaps have disappeared, but that the number of possible witnesses and documentary sources has expanded beyond one central collector.

Overall Critical Judgment: Justice Must Be Made

The most important achievement of The Work of the Defeated is its return from punishment imagined within the conscience to work undertaken in public. Ananya's game without an excluding line, Devika's telephone, Nishant's financial analogy, Soumya's translation, Meera's defence of privacy, Ira's reading of names and Gop's empty columns become different media of a common social question. Certain moral formulas recur, and the effectiveness of change occasionally appears too readily achieved. These limitations should not obscure the chapter's principal achievement: people who have suffered do not remain in an auditorium awaiting the next declaration of opposition. They begin work for those who will come after them, using the languages and materials of their own lives.

Inter-Sectional Assessment: Part I, Chapters 24–31

Across these eight chapters the novel simultaneously fashions the self-consciousness of a new beginning, the psychological instability of five major antagonists and the practical reorganisation of a living community. In Chapter 24 Ananya takes the notebook from the author's hand. Chapter 25 leaves the mind hanging. In Chapter 26 Batuknath travels by rail towards learning to read names; in 27 Chandrapal watches images of the village on his screen; in 28 Raghav's preferred language of disappearance fills with unwanted voices; in 29 Lau, overseas, experiences fear within the waters of his own profits; in 30 the inward courts of the five are opened successively; and in 31 those regarded as defeated divide the work of society. Outer journeys, imaginary dreams, supernatural hearing

and popular education reinforce one another without belonging to identical narrative registers.

Three principal risks of construction nevertheless require attention. First, the temporal relationship between Batuknath's village visit in Chapter 23 and his subsequent arrival in Chapter 26 remains unclear. It may be read as cyclic arrangement, but the absence of an explicit connection also permits the recognition of a textual inconsistency. Second, Ujjwal's death beside the water in Chapter 8 differs from images of a rope or hanging in Chapters 16 and 29; the contradiction remains unresolved. Third, the counting of five antagonists and four cities in Chapter 30 needs particular care. The criticism identifies these self-contradictory places rather than harmonising them by fabricating events.

Repeated supernatural images of green leaves, names appearing on glass and wet paper remain powerful, although their recurrence risks becoming predictable. The narrative grows more intimate when Ananya makes and corrects errors, Munna's vulnerability receives attention, Meera controls the terms of her pledge, Soumya translates, and Gop leaves spaces blank. Instead of imposing a Navya-Nyaya system or the false certainty of a legal verdict, the analysis focuses on temporal arrangement, focalisation, voice, the distribution of symbols, inter-narrative recurrence, and the creative as well as textual possibilities of inconsistency.

Critical Section 133 | Original Chapter 32 — The Third Kabaddi

The Narrative Necessity of a Third Game

The Third Kabaddi introduces another arrangement after the first ghostly match and the rewritten game of living children. Three distinct sides now participate: the dead, the boys and girls of the school, and the "minds" of the five antagonists. In the first game, supernatural inhabitants of the grove questioned the meaning of an event; in the second, the living accepted responsibility for reading names; in the third, those implicated in exploitation are made to enter the rules of the game themselves. This three-tiered construction indicates development without declaring that communal justice has been fully achieved. The gradual transformation of kabaddi keeps the novel's idea of justice in motion. It is not a repeated contest with merely different contestants but an altered account of who may speak, question and be questioned.

A Line Drawn by Itself: The Place's Independent Will

Lines emerge in the soil of Channa Grove without lime, string or a stick. Some are crooked like a river; others are indistinct like wounds. Instead of an ordinary rectangular kabaddi ground, the markings rewrite the geography of suffering. The grove is not simply a hall in which principles are discussed but a sensitive place that appears to disclose its own memory. The self-forming lines are not legal evidence. They belong to the magical narrative convention through which the earth bears human history. Their irregularity is essential: a fixed sporting boundary yields to marks that evoke both the changing river and the damaged lives associated with it. The apparent will of the setting becomes a narrative way of asking whose experiences have marked a particular place.

Three Forms: Body, Name and Mind

The dead participate as names, the children as bodies and breath, and the wrongdoers as minds. The latter's actual bodies remain in their respective cities, mansions, offices and glass houses. This distinction prevents the mistaken conclusion that the game depicts their physical arrest. Each group's presence obeys a different temporal rule: the dead are recalled after death, the children ask questions in the present, and the antagonists' minds move between anxiety and suppressed memories. Such unequal modes of participation do not reproduce the formal equality of a legal hearing. They constitute an imagined drama of social conscience. The effect depends upon their non-equivalence; were they all treated as bodily

players occupying the same verifiable place, the episode would lose its specifically narratological structure.

Sarayu's Breath and the Failed Repetition of "Procedure"

In the first turn Sarayu repeats her own name, each utterance leaving a mark on the ground. Batuknath's mind repeats "procedure," but his breath runs short. The verbal contest sets an individual's name, sustained by memory, against the narrowing posture of a procedure used to delay. It would be inaccurate to turn the scene into a denunciation of every legitimate use of legal process. The target is this character's exploitation of procedural language. The supernatural embodiment gives the oppressed person's name a durability denied to the technical expression when it becomes a defensive reflex. The scene thus challenges a particular application of professional knowledge without claiming that judicial procedure itself must disappear.

Ananya's Breath of "Question": A Civic Act

Ananya enters saying "question." When Chandrapal tempts her with a first prize, she asks about the debt concealed behind the promised gain. The outcome depends less on bodily capture than on economic judgment. Knowledge acquired in the earlier school chapters has entered the actions of a trained child protagonist. The narrator presents curiosity not as innocent ignorance but as an analysis capable of interrupting the structure of enticement. A question ceases to be a short moral slogan and becomes a method of examination. This is how the educational narrative and the supernatural game join: the child's acquired habit of asking what follows an offer is tested against an opponent's scripted incentives.

The Rapid Tempo of Chandrapal's Advertisements

Chandrapal's mind flashes like a screen, producing prizes, bonuses, instant earnings, counterfeit police threats and invitations to surrender an account. Narrative speed mimics the flicker of these offers. Devika's slower educational questioning interrupts the rush. The conflict of rhythms is important: the perpetrators want rapid decisions, whereas communal safety requires time. Once the child asks who truly owns the account, the pretence of free choice begins to break down. What is exposed is not merely fear but an invisible hierarchy of control. The scene therefore opposes the speed of manipulation to the deliberate temporal discipline of inquiry. As with the other magical contests, this disruption does not establish an actual regulatory finding; it dramatises what education may teach prospective victims to notice.

From “Mule” Back to Munna

Chandrapal slips outside the circle, but Munna Paswan's account remains behind him. By giving the account the presence of a human body, the narrative reverses the dehumanising effect of the financial category. Munna refuses the word “mule” and speaks his own name. This is a recovery of individual recognition. Yet the degree of possible responsibility for the misuse of the account remains a separate question for formal inquiry; uttering his name is not an acquittal issued by a court. The novel gives a central place to an ordinary young man's perspective precisely because the vocabulary of instrumental finance has obscured his circumstances. The game invites the audience to distinguish the operator who designs the network from the person whose identity is used within it.

Raghav's Breath of Erasure Meets Resistance

Raghav tries to enter the ground with the word “erase,” but every breath leaves a leaf behind. The earlier image of messages that survive deletion is converted into a rule of play. Meera raises the rights associated with photographs and privacy. Raghav's defence—that he merely transmitted materials—is put under pressure by the proposition that transmitting something may itself shape what happens to others. The scene is a dramatic social accusation, not the formal proof of a specific offence. Its narrative force arises from the mismatch between the character's supposed neutrality as an intermediary and the actual consequences that circulation can produce. The magical leaves make visible the traces he has habitually tried to remove.

Lau's Percentages and Nand's Plan of the Bridge

Lau plays to the rhythm of percentages, his words organised by profit and externally calculated risk. Nand Aruni confronts him with a plan of the bridge in which the piers have been replaced by names. This restores the absent workers to the process that produced the economic structure. The memory of the old water burial is connected to the more recent forms of financial exploitation. The risk is that distinct forms of suffering may be too readily assimilated to a single crocodile metaphor. Nand's concrete plan partly counteracts that danger by retaining a specific history of workers and construction. The financial diagram is thus answered not by a generic accusation alone, but by an alternate way of representing the labour that made the project possible.

Translating Broome's “Dignity”

Edward Broome's mind says “dignity.” Ira asks, in Maithili, in whose language dignity is being spoken. The refined vocabulary of a prestigious speaker confronts his unfamiliarity with the local names. An English

ethical term suddenly exposes the private calculations of gain attached to it. Ira does not reject another language in an act of revenge; she questions linguistic power by asserting the right of those who suffered to be named in their own speech. Still, one inward alteration of a word by Broome is not an established acknowledgment of every decision in his corporate organisation. The scene exposes the unstable moral basis of a speech while withholding the conclusion that the speaker has legally confessed.

Temporal Compression in the Distribution of Breath

Names are the refrain of the dead, questions that of the children, while the minds of the antagonists repeat “procedure,” “earnings,” “erase,” “percentage” and “dignity.” Day and night, years, trials and private histories converge within a single breath. This compression of time brings the long existence of the supernatural figures into strange proximity with the momentary life of a message on a mobile screen. The narrative does not attempt to reproduce a chronological sequence of real events; it gathers multiple layers of experience into a dramatic instant. Readers consequently move between a game apparently taking place and a metaphorical reconsideration of the preceding plot. The scene's simultaneous times are a compositional device, not a claim that all events occurred on one calendar date.

Leaving Five Words Behind

The antagonists may leave the field, but each must abandon a favourite word of power: procedure, account, message, share or dignity. The punishment is not physical confinement. Their language has entered public questioning and they are losing exclusive control over words previously used to conceal exploitation. The community begins to redefine those terms. This method avoids a spectacle of direct bodily violence, but it does not provide the compensation, investigation or institutional reform that still remain necessary. Its logic is linguistic and moral: words that once served as protective screens have become objects of scrutiny. The game thereby turns the power to name into a shared activity rather than the property of those who manage legal and commercial documents.

Loth Rises and the Spectator's Position Changes

Loth and others who had remained spectators through many chapters now move into the circle and laugh at Lau's diminished mind. This shift of action gives momentary agency to figures previously allotted the narrowest right of participation. Neither the children nor the dead keep the antagonists' minds bound. The objective is not perpetual torment but the public visibility of moral questions. Loth's rising follows the earlier moments in which the character obtained a limited opportunity to testify.

The change is therefore part of a slow redistribution of roles across the long narrative. It makes inclusion visible as a change in action, not only as an assertion that every voice ought to matter.

An Open Ending that Begins Again

At the end, a fallen leaf announces that things should begin again, and the villagers do not celebrate a day of victory. The children return to their school while the antagonists remain troubled. This recurring self-conclusion resembles Chapter 24, but it creates a risk: if the narrator announces every successive stage as another rebirth, actual developments may become harder to distinguish. What is new here is the three-sided construction of the game, the provisional abandonment of words and the interruption of advertising's rapid rhythm through questions. The return to instruction rather than celebration prevents a false finality. Yet the repeated announcement of renewed beginnings itself becomes a feature of the novel's narrative self-consciousness, inviting further critical scrutiny.

Critical Section 134 | Original Chapter 33 — The Examination of the Mind

The Rule of Examination in the Fourth Breath

The next breath of the third kabaddi introduces a rule: someone who has erased a name cannot leave the ground without pronouncing it in full. In the previous turns the physical circle or mental terror predominated; now the antagonists' own language is placed under interrogation. The declaration of the ghostly elder is not a formal court order but an ethical discipline belonging to the game. The renewed utterance of a name may be read as a restricted beginning of accountability. It is not full atonement. The rule also marks a formal progression: after losing possession of their favoured words, the antagonists must try to use language that has meaning beyond the security of their professions. Speech becomes a test rather than a means of evasion.

The Development of Ananya's Question

Ananya's earlier childhood questions arose upon seeing pictures of death. She now directs her questions towards the minds of living wrongdoers. This temporal change shows a gradual development from distressed curiosity to active ethical inquiry. The same questioning disposition receives a new object. Yet it would contradict the novel's plurality of voices to turn Ananya into an all-knowing judge. Other children work beside her, and the information about names comes from the dead, their families and the school. Her contribution is the manner of questioning rather than exclusive access to every answer. The scene honours the initiative of a young protagonist without making her a substitute for the difficult labour of gathering testimony.

Names Rejected by Batuknath's Tongue

Batuknath attempts to enumerate “procedure,” “case,” “admissibility” and “jurisdiction,” but “Sarayu Devi” and “Lakhan Paswan” emerge from his mouth. The scene represents an involuntary utterance of memory: the names of those who suffered puncture a professional vocabulary. The linguistic disturbance is more forceful here than another sentimental recollection of childhood. However, the spontaneous appearance of a name does not mean Batuknath has learned everything about the person's household or history. Pronunciation is the first disruption of his habitual language, not a complete reconstruction of the past. The uncanny reversal makes institutional terminology briefly yield to particular persons while showing how much further inquiry remains necessary.

Chandrapal's Accounts Become a Human Register

On the screen that constitutes Chandrapal's mind, young account holders associated with the network appear in a line. Ujjwal, Munna and unnamed students are no longer financial items but social individuals. Devika observes from a distance what the knowledge carried by the children is making possible; she need not leap into the game herself. Resistance has moved from the command of a single heroic figure to collective practice. The embodied register opposes Chandrapal's word "users" with the invocation of people. The scene is an exercise in transforming categories of economic convenience into relations that demand inquiry. Nevertheless, the change of visual form is not yet a complete verification of every entry in the network's records.

Raghav Experiences Being a "Mule" Himself

Surrounded by leaves, Raghav calls for Lau's assistance. The response—"use ended"—makes him realise for the first time that he too can be a disposable link in the larger network. His insecurity is real within the scene but is not the same as the circumstances of the impoverished account holders he helped exploit. Experiencing his own disposability differs from fully understanding another person's suffering. The parallel exposes a crack in his pride. Its critical value lies in retaining the imbalance: Raghav's vulnerability does not cancel his earlier agency, and the discovery that a superior is willing to discard him does not automatically transform him into the moral equivalent of those coerced or deceived by the scheme.

Lau's Limits in the Language of Names

Lau does not know Maithili, yet he experiences the moment of pronouncing Ujjwal's name. The linguistic barrier is not merely an emblem of national difference. It tests the capacity to recognise a particular person beyond the abstraction of profit. Through the sound of a name, an anonymous "customer" begins to become an unstable human presence. Nevertheless, correct pronunciation cannot by itself communicate the linguistic, cultural and familial circumstances of the dead person. Later chapters extend this incompleteness towards home, fear and aspiration. Here the act of naming is meaningful precisely as an opening. It must not be mistaken for the completion of understanding or restitution by a distant architect of the network.

Ujjwal's Presence without Direct Appearance

Although Lau pronounces his name, Ujjwal does not immediately return to the field as a visible figure. Instead, the novel specifies that his memory gains meaning when children learn, through Devika's instruction, to recognise deception. The peace of the dead is not reduced to a sole magical

verdict. The protection of the living is given its place. This is a notable balance in the narrative: the author resists the temptation to summon the ghost into every scene. The significance of the absent young man travels through the actions of people who remember him. The absence remains real, and learning does not reverse the narrated death.

From Broome's Dignity to Price and Name

Broome pronounces “human dignity.” On the leaf, the word becomes “price” and then “name.” This compact phonetic transformation brings the economic valuation of people, the moral phrase of a speech and human identity into contact. As the confidence of a speaker accustomed to applause falters, public ethics can no longer be easily detached from private gain. The very neatness of the symbol, however, may seem reductive to some readers, particularly when each antagonist's falsehood is instantly given a perfect translation on a leaf. The passage's artistic gain is lucidity; its risk is oversimplification. The scene remains a symbolic disturbance, not the verified substance of an official public statement.

Teaching Rather than Capturing

In the fourth breath nobody is imprisoned or physically defeated. A player who cannot say the name must sit at the edge of the ground. The game's effect is not the destruction of the wrongdoer but a public image of incomplete human education. An important qualification remains: those who suffered have no perpetual duty to educate their abusers. The independent work of the village school is the main social undertaking. The narrator imagines a moral exercise rather than furnishing a full model of restorative justice with its necessary consent, safeguards and procedures. Sitting at the edge signifies unfinished learning, not a verdict that the harm can be repaired through instruction alone.

Re-reading the Winner's Sorrow

The ghostly elder offers the image of victory rotting when it is without sorrow. This reprises the concern of The Grief of Victory, but sorrow now appears as a possible condition for self-knowledge rather than merely an outcome. Chandrapal wants security, not acknowledgment; consequently his inner fear remains unsettled. His continuing preoccupation is personal safety. The narrative makes this limitation clear even as the elder repeatedly explains the moral significance of the encounter. Such explanations can forestall readers' own interpretations. The more compelling feature is the contrast between the defensive desire to feel safe and the difficult task of understanding the lives affected by one's actions.

Meera's Voice and Raghav's Mirror

Raghav tries to remove the leaves bearing deleted messages, but one clings to his palm. The text says he has received a mirror rather than a prison. Meera's earlier insistence upon privacy is relevant to this image: the mirror forces the perpetrator to confront his own participation without granting anyone the right to publish a victim's intimate materials. Literary justice here imagines self-examination imposed upon the oppressor. The distinct duty to protect private information must remain in force. The difference prevents a paradox in which a story condemning the theft of information repeats that theft in the name of exposure. The mirror concerns Raghav's conduct; it is not a public licence over Meera's correspondence.

Loth Moves from Spectator to Player

The ghosts at times withdraw from their positions as arbiters, and those who had always only watched gain entry into play. This change of role is not ornamental detail attached to the villains' humiliation. It represents a new circulation of narrative authority. The exclusion of listeners, spectators and marginal figures is challenged by allowing them to act. In miniature, the scene gives the novel's claim to social inclusion a form that can be examined in terms of actual agency. The ghosts cease to control every utterance, just as the earlier chapters began transferring the responsibility for memory to living children. Participation becomes a changing practice rather than a timeless status.

Five Minds Waiting at the Edge

At the close, all five antagonists' minds sit along the edge of the ground while the children remain in the centre. Ananya assigns the task of finding one full name for the next breath. No one has completely repented; no one has received a fresh conviction in an external court. This unfinished condition sustains the tension of the game. The chapter does not conclude with the total defeat of individuals but with the opening of another category of investigation. The physical arrangement of the players conveys the redistribution of attention: the children now determine what must be learned, while the antagonists remain unable to leave without facing the incompleteness of their knowledge.

Critical Conclusion

The Examination of the Mind is distinctive in its use of the wrongdoers' own instruments to unsettle them: legal terms become names, users become people, deleted messages become leaves, percentages require individual pronunciation, and dignity is tested against price. Its temporal device is the announced fourth breath. Yet the rhythm of its images is extremely close to that of the preceding chapters. The narrative achieves

greater force when Ananya asks not merely whether a name can be uttered but what relation it bears to a living household. Through that question the exercise moves beyond magical verbal correction. Naming becomes the beginning of an encounter with a social history which the game alone cannot supply.

Critical Section 135 | Original Chapter 34 — The Listening River

Silence as a Form of Hearing

The Listening River begins with silence after the fourth breath. This is not peace. The river seems to arrest its current in order to listen to the utterances coming from its banks. The folk conception of a sensitive river extends the supernatural location of ghostly kabaddi towards objects in distant cities. No longer merely a background to events, the river becomes an active listener within the story. Its hearing belongs to the novel's supernatural conventions; it is not a hydrological occurrence. This silence prepares the next act of reading names, and it remains crowded with unfinished questions. The narrator does not transform the natural world into scientific testimony. The river's imagined attention gives physical shape to a community's demand that unheard lives should finally be listened to.

Mud in Batuknath's Bathroom

In the security of his Delhi house, muddy water emerges from Batuknath's tap. His first reaction is to become angry with the household employees. This reaction repeats his habit of reducing disturbing experiences to ordinary technical faults. The smell of the water brings the piers of the Ganges bridge and the dust of the grove into the privacy of an apparently spotless urban home. The transfer is one of the narrative's significant physical transformations. Yet this water is not a replacement for a collected and tested sample. It represents the pressure of the victims' memory upon Batuknath's domestic comfort. The uncanny intrusion matters because the character's protected interior can no longer remain insulated from the social history his legal vocabulary has concealed.

“The Case Is Closed” Becomes “The Name Is Incomplete”

Batuknath expects to read “case closed” in the court order, but sees “name incomplete” instead. The novel distinguishes two kinds of finality: the procedural conclusion of a case and the unfinished work of social memory. On the legal plane, the varied accounts of the original lawsuit and its orders remain unclear, and the magical writing does not reconstruct a complete procedural history. At the level of narration, however, official paper appears to acknowledge its own limitation. The incompleteness of a name becomes a new cause for storytelling. The altered phrase resists the assumption that the end of a filing or hearing exhausts what must be known about a person. Its truth is figurative and ethical rather than judicially verified.

Chandrapal's Image Changes when He Opens the Safe

Chandrapal's safe contains seals, money, papers concerning foreign accounts and devices connected with telephones. He regards this as an impregnable store of things he controls. The return of the leaf of memory, however, makes even his most protected private space unstable. The contents of the safe gather the instruments of financial exploitation into a single scene: seals, accounts and phones. The depiction should not be enlarged into a general indictment of every consultant or legal institution. It concerns the particular character and the network constructed around him. The safe's symbolic failure lies in the discovery that possession of documents and objects is not equivalent to control over their ethical meaning. The scene exposes the nervousness beneath apparent mastery.

Raghav's Lost Voice and His Written Codes

Raghav tries to speak in the morning but produces no voice. He attempts to write a person's name, yet his hand makes alphanumeric codes automatically. The twofold impairment involves speech and writing: both have become habituated to systems that erase human names. The character whose work depends on signals and secret figures encounters the bodily difficulty of learning another language of recognition. This is psychological helplessness staged through a magical sign, not a dependable medical diagnosis. The scene also differs from merely showing deleted messages recurring. Raghav cannot freely produce the kind of name he has systematically replaced with numbers. His instruments of communication no longer guarantee that he can communicate something humanly specific.

The Unfinished Name on a Leaf: Searching for Folk Sources

At the coconut-leaf school, the children find a pebble carrying half a written name. Its missing portion must be sought from elders, workers' families, old registers or songs of the river. The exercise asks for patient listening before the hurried act of writing. Searching for a name becomes a collective interview rather than a demonstration of spontaneous supernatural knowledge. If a folk song, a relative's recollection and an official register provide different versions, the critic must keep those versions identifiable instead of simply imposing a guessed final form. The scene makes incompleteness productive: a visible fragment creates a responsibility to ask questions. Yet that responsibility is only fulfilled by sustained attention to the provenance and limits of what each source knows.

The Full Identity in Devika's Teaching

Devika teaches the significance of a person's full identity in a setting where fraudulent callers rely upon vague claims to authority and terms such as customer, accused or consumer. The school's emphasis on recognising one's own name is an attempt to break such confusing language. Nevertheless, practical digital safety also requires caution about revealing private information unnecessarily to unknown callers. The chapter's injunction to speak one's name should therefore be understood as a figure of social self-identification, not an instruction applicable without qualification to every telephone exchange. This distinction is especially important in a narrative already concerned with data theft and blackmail. Teaching the right to be recognised cannot become advice to surrender identifying details to a stranger.

Names on the Pages of a Law Book

Batuknath opens a legal text and sees names in place of provisions. He recalls his teacher's admonition not to murder truth through procedure. This is a dramatic rereading of his own education. The scene does not repudiate legal study. It criticises the use of legal words that ignores the people to whom law is meant to apply. The teacher's memory resembles the earlier recurrence of his father's instruction. Yet the frequent arrival of such moral advice risks covering the character's inner complexity with an explanatory layer. The uncanny change of the page is effective as a symbol of a profession confronting its purpose; it is less effective if every hidden ethical question is immediately answered by a perfectly formulated saying from the past.

Homes Appear in Chandrapal's Accounts

On Chandrapal's numerical profit display appear Munna's father's torn shirt, Ujjwal's home, documents and other details of individual lives. The transformed screen joins financial abstraction to the recognition of material social existence. Chandrapal closes his eyes, for seeing and accepting are different acts. Ananya's questioning tests precisely that distinction. A beginning of inward change may be perceived, but it has not been established as completed. The display turns entries into images of homes and persons without making all the entries into authenticated case histories. Its contribution to the sequence is to reveal that the monetary units by which Chandrapal measures his operations conceal the bodily and familial circumstances of people who are not free to treat their own losses as abstractions.

The Possibility and Limits of Turning Codes into Names

Fragments of Raghav's torn paper reach the school, and the children practise recovering names from codes. This is the people's linguistic reply to the coded language of crime. In actual record-keeping, however, the inference of a particular person's name from an ambiguous code could introduce serious errors. Within the source the episode is part of a magical narrative. The critic must not present an unknown name as definitely reconstructed through invented completion. The underlying impulse is to search for the person concealed behind a code. The method's ethical value depends upon accepting the difference between a clue and a verified identity. The scene's imaginative transformation should inspire investigation, not replace it.

Lau's Adviser Says "Give It Time"

At the overseas meeting, a specialist predicts that the village's emotional story will tire people out with time. When Lau asks what will happen if it does not fall silent, his private fear becomes audible amid the confidence of commercial crisis management. The adviser's language is a narrative form of managing threats to the network. It is not a reliable comprehensive measurement of the movement's social reach. The author contrasts assumptions about the exhaustion of public feeling with the recurring image of a village learning to change its breath. Time is thereby disputed: business advisers expect attention to decay, while the community uses repetition to sustain memory. Neither expectation has yet been conclusively tested across the entire network.

The River Listens and the House Asks Questions

In the hearing of the fifth breath, Batuknath attempts to say Sarayu Devi's name in full; Chandrapal begins to encounter Ujjwal as a person rather than a "user"; Raghav struggles to leave the language of codes; Lau falters before the threshold of a name. The bowl of water and the attempted pronunciations are not merely gratuitous magical penalties. They represent a further education in the social meaning of language. The five are not shown progressing uniformly. Some achieve partial speech, others contemplate escape, and still others try to modify what they say in public. The unequal development is important: to speak an uncomfortable word is not necessarily to have surrendered the conduct or power that made the word difficult.

Beyond Saying a Name: Reaching a Home

The ghostly elder insists that pronouncing a name is not freedom: one must now reach the person's home. This extension of the task moves the novel from a symbolic litany of names towards a concrete test of social

relations. Linking a name to a household and familial history may improve the ethical credibility of the folk archive. Yet arrival at someone's door must not become an unauthorised visit or a fresh threat, especially in view of unequal power between the visitors and the bereaved. That caution follows from the novel's own concern with dignity and consent. A name is not an unrestricted passport into private life. The next stage of inquiry has to learn not only where someone lived but whether the family wishes to receive the person asking.

Critical Judgment

The Listening River does not complete an alternative judicial record. It identifies the violence of hearing only half of a name. Muddy tap water, a spontaneously altered legal page, coded writing, children's pebbles, the scent of the river and the bowl of words form a symbolic sequence. Its strongest achievement is the movement of memory from an external river into the private language of people implicated in its suffering. A stylistic risk remains: nearly every room contains a comparable supernatural obstacle that produces a predetermined moral lesson. The next chapter introduces the firmer resistance of an actual human encounter at a threshold. That movement from the river's impossible hearing to a household's right to answer or refuse is crucial to the developing narrative.

Critical Section 136 | Original Chapter 35 — The Threshold of the Name

The Threshold after Pronunciation

The water of the fifth breath does not sink into the soil but circulates through the roots. Five miniature outlines of houses appear in the grove: those associated with Sarayu, Munna, Ujjwal, an unknown worker and a household without a name. These domestic places reveal histories beyond the bare identification of persons. The novel now asks who someone was, how far away the person lived and what losses were left at home. Verbal honour becomes a geographical and relational point of inquiry. The significance of the threshold is that a name cannot be adequately understood as an isolated entry. It opens towards family, labour, the place of return and the sometimes inaccessible life that survives the person.

The Question of Batuknath's Journey Beginning Again

Batuknath took a train towards the village in Chapter 26, and in Chapter 35 he takes one again after his car breaks down; an earlier visit was already described in Chapter 23. This creates a clear problem of event continuity. It is possible that the narrative is layering inward and outward journeys through repetition, but the place and time of each journey are not sufficiently distinguished. The criticism leaves the issue unresolved rather than inserting an invented date of return or a new lawsuit to reconcile the sequence. A cyclical interpretation may have artistic value, but the factual order still requires scrutiny. Recurrence in a narrative can be intentional without every inconsistency necessarily becoming an intentional device.

The Return of the Elderly Fellow Traveller

On the train Batuknath again encounters the old traveller. The earlier journey of the antagonist's mind is now guided by the repeated intervention of an uncanny companion. The elder's instruction to read names becomes the practical demand to touch a threshold. Recurring expressions sustain the rhythm of the story, though repeated supernatural intervention may also diminish the reader's sense of novelty. Within this ambivalence, a living elderly woman enters later in the chapter. Her question carries a social weight different from the ghost's. The contrast is essential: the ghost can conduct an ethical examination within the imaginative order, but the living woman's response belongs to a household bearing the actual consequences of loss.

The Remains of Sarayu's House

Sarayu Devi's home appears as a partially ruined wall, a changed roof, a grass-covered courtyard and a surviving threshold. These details are not merely picturesque signs of sadness. They are material indications of a domestic history left behind. The threshold cannot restore the house's entire life, but it preserves a location, a possible route of return and a social centre for memory. The question of whether Sarayu's familial description coheres with earlier chapters remains open. Her full biography cannot be reconstructed from the new threshold alone. The scene's force comes precisely from the fragmentary survival of place: a ruin may testify to absence while leaving many details unknown.

The Order Batuknath Cannot Place on the Threshold

Batuknath tries to lay the order proclaiming his victory upon the threshold but cannot bring himself to do so. The paper acquires unexpected weight. This gesture does not reject law in its entirety; it reveals the discomfort of a particular person's habitual use of paper to exert control. At the threshold lie questions of intimate life that his professional command of legal expressions has not taught him to answer. The scene is powerful because the eloquent lawyer becomes silent before a courtyard. The order remains in his possession, but the act of displaying it as the final word has become impossible in the presence of a household's surviving material history.

Dust from an Elderly Woman: The Beginning of Seeing

An elderly woman places dust in Batuknath's hand and tells him that if he wishes to read a person completely he must put it near the corner of his eye. Dust is an extraordinary counter-object to spectacles, degrees, titles and layered case files. Contact with the soil replaces the privilege of viewing people through official documents. When Batuknath touches it, Sarayu's final labouring scene appears before him. The magical vision is a possibility of change within the character, not a fully verified re-enactment of an incident for an official register. It enables the past to be felt in the present while maintaining the distinction between imaginative insight and proof. Crucially, the woman controls the lesson instead of simply accepting his declaration that he has come to understand.

The Limits of “I Had Read Her Only Partly”

Batuknath tries to introduce himself through the Bar Council, but finally admits that he had read Sarayu incompletely. This is a partial self-recognition expressed in speech, not a public confession of criminal guilt. The elderly woman does not immediately offer him honour or water. She gives him work to do: write. The encounter opens a new direction for the

character without obliging the relatives of those harmed to act as instruments of a wrongdoer's emotional rebirth. That ethical balance is indispensable. An apology or admission of ignorance may matter, but the household retains the authority to withhold welcome, demand evidence and decide what form of participation is acceptable.

Chandrapal's Distant Screen and Ujjwal's Bed

Chandrapal does not physically visit Ujjwal's home. On his telephone he sees tooth marks in a pillow. Devika describes them as traces of her brother's attempt to suppress his crying. Beyond financial data, the image becomes an unexpected bodily indication of fear. Chandrapal closes the screen, but the marks remain in his imagination. A distant image is not equivalent to an actual visit to the household, a distinction that Ananya repeats in her later question. The technique briefly brings the interior of the young man's home into contact with Chandrapal's protected world while keeping their physical separation visible. Seeing an image can begin a difficult recognition, but it does not establish consent, accountability or an understanding of every private circumstance.

Raghav Practises Writing a Full Name

Raghav moves from the initial “m” of “mule” towards writing Munna's full name. The change in vocabulary shifts from a banking category that erases individuality to the identification of a social person. But the claim that Munna is not a criminal is Raghav's statement within the narrative, not a formal judgment. The reader must retain the distinctions between Raghav's former conduct and Munna's knowledge and circumstances. Having written the name in full, Raghav begins to look for a more precise village address. The movement points towards verification through sources, rather than the assumption that writing a name means the inquiry is finished. In this limited sense, language begins to direct the character towards a real social location.

Thresholds on Lau's Market Map

On Lau's map of India, the marks for banking nodes, consumer concentrations and payment points become innumerable thresholds. The flat space of commercial data becomes a multitude of family spaces. Business advisers consider ways to purchase rural sentiment, while Lau's vision questions the attempt to confine households within a customer list. The disappearance of the financial map does not mean the actual banking data have vanished. It is a disturbance in a character's perception, through which social life invades the economic abstraction that has organised his thinking. The narrative therefore contrasts the representation of

profitable markets with the unpurchasable permission required to enter a person's home.

Broome Mispronounces a Name

On a global stage, Broome sees a slide of thresholds and tries to pronounce Sarayu Devi's name, but reads it incorrectly. This error creates an uneasy relation between learning and the language of apology. A mispronunciation is not in every circumstance an offence. Yet when failure to know a person's name belongs to a history of institutional disregard, an attempt to learn may acquire significance. Broome's polite expression of sorrow is insufficient; the ghostly elder asks that he listen in the language of the people who suffered. The test will be his subsequent action, not the mere appearance of an apologetic tone. An unfamiliar name challenges the speaker's confident command of universal ethical language by demanding attention to particular speech.

Four Lines in the Game of "Tell Us the Home"

In the children's altered kabaddi, one child speaks a name, another describes the home, a third mentions fear and a fourth the dream. If the information is incomplete, the name is treated as still unfinished. This is an excellent dramatic device for popular record-keeping, since the inscription of a name in a notebook does not by itself give the full history of a life. At the same time, the facts about home, fear and dream will not always be available. The new demand must be reconciled with the earlier rule that unknown spaces should remain blank. A responsible archive cannot turn a desire for completeness into permission to imagine missing private details. The game is most effective as a programme of questions, not a machine for guaranteeing answers.

Permission and Conditions at the Threshold

In the night's game, Batuknath stands at Sarayu's threshold; the threshold of Ujjwal's home withdraws from Chandrapal; Munna's threshold trembles near Raghav; Lau cannot become a guest at millions of thresholds; Broome stumbles in the language of a name. The five responses differ, despite the grouping of the antagonists in one dramatic exercise. A village household is not something that can be bought, and permission is necessary before crossing into its courtyard. The image therefore refuses to turn the victims' homes into free stages for the self-purification of those implicated in harm. The symbol is more ethically exacting than a simple demand for public apology: an invitation cannot be presumed, even by a visitor seeking to demonstrate regret.

Overall Critical Assessment

The Threshold of the Name converts the novel's conceptual metaphor into concrete images: a ruined house, dust, a pillow, a torn shirt and the silence of an elderly woman. Its strongest feature is the refusal to proclaim completed repentance. It remains at the threshold of beginning to see. The uncertain repetition of Batuknath's journeys, the exceptionally planned symbolism of the thresholds and the repeated similarity of supernatural punishments are risks of construction. Yet the movement from “name” to “home” is a significant artistic extension. It asks whether a word uttered in public has been connected to the history of the person who bore it, and whether those still living possess the right to answer the speaker on their own terms.

Critical Section 137 | Original Chapter 36 — Home, Fear, Dream

Three Circles within the Seventh Breath

Having reached the threshold of the name, the narrative asks three further questions about what lies behind it: home, fear and dream. Ananya draws three circles in the soil, placing pebbles between them. The arrangement is not merely a children's game; it offers a framework for organising the otherwise difficult-to-know history of a life. A name provides outward identification; a home gives social location, fear expresses present insecurity, and a dream indicates an unfulfilled future. “Home” thus provides the context without which a dead person's name might remain one-dimensional in a public list. The seventh breath changes the act of remembrance from repeating names into seeking the relationships, anxieties and aspirations that made each person singular.

Sarayu's Hearth and the Waiting Child

Inside Sarayu's threshold appear half-cooked rice, smoke and a child waiting for the mother to come home. Batuknath wants to ask about procedural evidence, but ash from the hearth forms the word “waiting” and falls upon his forehead. The scene reveals the difference between the time of records and the time of the household. In a register, a dead worker can be described as “absent”; at home, unfinished food, the hour of a meal and a child's waiting reveal the human cost of that absence. The supernatural hearth is not an independent form of forensic proof. It is an ethical and sensory image within the fiction. Its strength lies in making the consequence of a missing name visible through an ordinary domestic act that can no longer be completed.

The Escalation of Fear inside Ujjwal's Home

Chandrapal enters Ujjwal's threshold. The sequence runs from the laughter of an initial win through debt and a counterfeit arrest to the breath arrested by fear. Devika shows the tooth marks upon the pillow. Digital debt, often represented by intangible figures, becomes bodily suffering. Chandrapal's defence that he was “only a consultant” fails to emerge as a complete sentence. Yet a magical failure of speech cannot replace a finding of legal or professional liability. It exposes the fragility of the character's self-protective account. The household's intimacy gives the criticism a stronger basis for recognising suffering than another abstract denunciation of the network: a single pillow bears the trace of distress without supplying all the missing facts of the case.

Munna's Mother's Cloth

Raghav comes to Munna Paswan's home, where a cloth, a bank sign and bricks associated with debt belong to a world very different from the screens he has habitually managed. Holding an old cloth, Munna's mother asks whether this was what had been promised as a job. Her simple question reveals the social setting of the original inducement. Raghav's coded vocabulary fails him. The failure marks a change in the character's memory, but it gives no reason to claim that the family's actual loss has been formally compensated. The mother's voice has a special authority because it refuses to reduce a life to an instrument of the payment network. The cloth restores a tangible history to the account-holder whose identity has been used by others.

The Household versus Consumer Data

In Lau's view, every customer point in India becomes a household threshold. His advisers can describe income, expenditure, tendencies to borrow and digital usage, but cannot give a satisfactory account of the human relationships that make a home. Economic data can be an ordinary instrument of calculation; the novel criticises its particularly exploitative application. Lau's question forces him to think beyond profit, but he has not thereby found every answer or undergone a complete moral transformation. The narrative sets the language of domestic relations against the abstractions of market segmentation without suggesting that every numerical measure is inherently dishonest. The trouble arises when an entire human life is treated only as a potentially profitable behavioural profile.

Broome's Attempt to Write “M”

Edward Broome leaves the fluency of international speeches and tries to write the Maithili letters of an apology, beginning with a word akin to “forgive me”; he converses with Elina Graves. His finger slides across the smooth page. The difficulty of this exercise reduces a prestigious global platform to the scale of a novice's classroom. Yet if learning the victims' language becomes a means of purchasing their approval, the character will simply have repeated the old logic of the market. The chapter therefore retains an unfinished phrase, imperfect pronunciation and an uncertain attempt. Beginning to learn is different from taking responsible action. Broome's apparent humility cannot cancel a history of institutional neglect or guarantee that an apology would be accepted.

Distinct Histories of Fear

Sarayu fears the hunger of her child; Ujjwal fears the humiliation of his sister; Munna fears being called a criminal without knowing why; Meera

fears that her love will be misused; Nand fears the disappearance of truth. These forms of fear share an emotional intensity without sharing a single causal structure. Financial pressures, social shame, sexual privacy and industrial violence remain distinct. The narrator produces a common ethical framework for popular instruction, but criticism must resist attributing every suffering to an identical source. The enumeration has value because it obliges the community to listen for the specific reason a person is afraid. A general promise of solidarity is not enough if it cannot respond appropriately to different threats.

Respect for Fear and the Dignity of Those Who Are Afraid

The children place a small lamp before each fear. Devika leads a pledge not to call a frightened person a coward, a defrauded person a fool, or someone subjected to blackmail guilty. This does not sanctify fear. It changes the social location of shame and blame. Fear does not vanish, but the possibility of isolation may diminish. Through this ceremony, the author stages a transformation in public language. The institutions responsible for fraud, the technical systems enabling it and the financial liabilities involved do not thereby disappear. The scene's immediate goal is a change in how people respond when someone asks for help. To recognise fear without humiliation is one precondition for the victim to speak, not a substitute for investigation or protection.

Raghav's Apology Is Stopped

Raghav bends before Munna's mother and reaches towards the edge of her cloth. She pulls it away and demands that he first disclose the truth about the account that was opened. This is the chapter's most complex moment of possible restoration. A victim's relative is not obliged to accept an offender's emotional gesture or grant immediate forgiveness. “Tell the truth” demands practical responsibility instead of an apologetic formula. The scene provides a firm human ground for the novel's repeated supernatural self-examinations. It shifts authority to the person who has suffered, who may refuse a touch, reject a performance of remorse and insist on verifiable information. The restraint is especially valuable in a narrative where magical symbols sometimes make inner moral transformations appear too easy.

Lau Defeated by the Question “Where Is Home?”

Lau tries to locate Garh Narikela on his map, but the question “Where is your home?” appears on the screen. Although his life contains property and luxury, he struggles with the meaning of belonging to a household. The device constructs a contrast between worldwide possessions and an experience bereft of human relationships. Yet homelessness or lack of

familial ties is not a general proof of moral guilt. The particular criticism concerns the emptiness of this exploitative character's economic vision: he has attempted to turn other people's homes into markets while failing to understand them as places of intimate and reciprocal life. The question exposes a contradiction in his perception rather than condemning everyone whose circumstances keep them far from a settled home.

Dream: Who Will Live the Future of the Dead?

The final circle is "dream." Sarayu wishes for her child's education, Ujjwal for Devika's freedom from fear, Munna for his father's dignity, Meera for the safety of love, and Nand for the names of bridge workers to survive. Collective instruction is no longer confined to lamenting the past. It becomes prospective work. Nevertheless, a dream attributed to someone who has died should not be treated as definitive biographical testimony merely because the narrator declares it. It expresses a communal aspiration within the memory of the person. Wherever possible, that aspiration must remain connected with what living relatives say and with the limits of available knowledge. The narrative is powerful in opening the future, but its ethical force depends upon refusing to invent unverified inner lives as historical certainty.

The Knot of Home, Fear and Dream, and the Pebbles

The children write letters upon pebbles in the three circles and bring them together, representing three unfinished aspects of an individual's story. This differs from the ordinary archive of names and dates. Every name initiates further questions; the register becomes an education in listening rather than merely a collection of facts. Yet not every family may wish to speak publicly of fear or aspiration. The community's right to remember must be limited by the individual's right to privacy. The most responsible version of the practice therefore allows unknown and undisclosed spaces to remain open. The pebbles make a memorable pedagogical form, but they should not become a demand that every life yield all its intimate details to a public memorial.

Homework Instead of a Verdict

At the end of the seventh breath, the ghostly elder declines to pronounce another final punishment and instead says: return after learning what you could not tell us. Judicial finality is displaced by unfinished social education. The antagonists have been given an opportunity to learn, but the future of those they harmed is not made dependent upon their repentance. Devika, Meera, Soumya and others continue their own work. This two-track structure saves the novel from waiting indefinitely for the dramatic transformation of its villains. An order to learn is a beginning,

not a pardon; the community's labour remains valuable whether or not the antagonists ever accept responsibility.

Conclusion: The Many Voices of Three Words

Home, Fear, Dream transforms the abstract ethics of naming into bodily encounters with food, cloth, pillows, debt, the school and refusal. Its human climax is the failure of Raghav's gesture towards Munna's mother's cloth. The recurrent supernatural questioning can still seem predictable, but the family's refusal preserves an indispensable human complexity. Inability to answer a question about home is not merely an occasion for humiliating a wrongdoer. It becomes an agenda for future social responsibility. The chapter's achievement lies in the insistence that a name must lead towards a life without giving investigators, memorial-makers or repentant offenders unrestricted authority over that life.

Critical Section 138 | Original Chapter 37 — Three Pebbles

The Three Pebbles of the Seventh Breath Travel from House to House

The three pebbles of the seventh breath in Channa Grove travel in children's pockets to school, the fields and their homes. A magical object belonging to the game thus becomes a portable practice of ordinary life. The clinking of the pebbles provides a new sound for an instrument of remembrance: people can ask about home, fear and dreams without having to stand in the grove. The narrator traces an important movement in the location of experience, from a ceremony centred upon Channa Grove to wider forms of social action. The pebbles are more than relics of the supernatural contest; their everyday circulation makes the game transferable. What was staged within one haunted space is gradually becoming an exercise of listening that can be repeated in the places where people live and work.

The Difference between Batuknath's Three Homes

Three pebbles appear beneath Batuknath's pillow. When asked to choose his home, he hesitates between an old lane in Madras, an affluent bungalow in Delhi and the chamber containing his legal files. These alternatives demonstrate that a home is not reducible to the address of one's present property. It may signify familial history, an acquired public identity or the professional structures on which a life has come to depend. The recollection of his father's earlier labour is particularly important, for it opens another possibility of self-recognition. Yet the critic must not turn experiences occurring within Batuknath's consciousness into an externally verified, complete biography. The scene matters as an exploration of his inward relation to place, and its uncertainty is inseparable from its narrative function.

Chandrapal's Days in the Meerut Hostel

Chandrapal sees three circles on his modern, protected screen, but the voices and spaces of his old hostel in Meerut return to him. His earlier professional life contained small legal cases, modest remuneration and the possibility of taking different paths. The narrator begins to present corruption not as an inborn destiny but as the accumulation of choices made within a career. The memory of Shamim, a friend from that earlier world, reinforces the proposition that a shared education need not lead to identical ethical conduct. Chandrapal's recollection does not erase the actions subsequently attributed to him. Rather, it interrupts the fatalistic explanation that a profitable and exploitative career could never have

developed otherwise. Retrospection opens a question about decisions; it does not manufacture an acquittal.

Raghav's Negative Inventory of Home

Raghav's house contains no old letters, photographs or diaries. His wife has left him, and his son calls him "sir" rather than "father." This catalogue of absence extends the earlier motif of technological silence into the erosion of familial relationships. Raghav believed that secrecy would confer security, but he has also erased the materials through which his own domestic history might have endured. The psychological characterisation differentiates the silent operator of the network from its more talkative participants. Yet the breakdown of his family does not automatically explain his criminal choices, nor is suffering a certificate of repentance. It should be read as an episode in Raghav's self-perception. The narrative's force derives from the paradox that a man devoted to deleting traces can no longer locate the ordinary traces of home.

The Seventh Floor of Lau's Maritime City

Lau sits on the seventh floor of a glass building in a maritime city, surrounded by reports on markets across several countries. Addiction, unemployment, weak legal scrutiny and rapid returns constitute the principal terms of his calculations. The three pebbles ask him what human relationships constitute the homes of the persons from whom profits are drawn. The narrator places the geography of markets and the emotional geography of home within the same frame. This is not the presentation of a precise economic model supported by data tables; the language sketches the symbolic profit-map through which the character views other lives. The question presses on the gap between an accurately identified customer segment and an understanding of the household within which a loss is endured. Lau's inability to answer remains an opening, not a completed moral conversion.

"Do Rogues Have Homes Too?"

A child in the school asks whether oppressors also have homes. Burhba the ghost replies that they do, although people abandon them. The exchange challenges the easy habit of making villains into inhuman beings and then dismissing their histories as irrelevant. Understanding the earlier life of an oppressor does not diminish the gravity of an oppressive act. Narrative complexity requires a balance between moral repudiation and an inquiry into the causes and choices that produced a life. Education here means neither praising the adversary nor asking the victims to surrender their claims. It means examining the circumstances and decisions through which the person came to occupy an exploitative role. The child forces the

story to distinguish accountability from the erasure of the accused person's humanity.

Documents of Origin in Gop's Bag

Gop Kumar produces old tickets, hostel receipts, training cards, identity papers from first employment and photographs. He explicitly warns that these items are not complete proof; they are starting clues. This self-imposed evidentiary limit is one of the novel's more convincing research-oriented features. The narrative moves towards the antagonists' biographies while retaining differences among kinds of sources. A ticket indicates a journey but does not by itself establish the meaning of every decision taken upon it. A photograph records a person in a particular context, not a full account of that person's offences. If a critic used these fragments to declare each accused person's criminal development conclusively established, the critic would reverse Gop's warning. The significance of the objects lies in beginning a disciplined inquiry rather than completing one.

Shamim's Alternative Course of Life

Chandrapal remembers his former friend Shamim. Both inhabited the same hostel and the world of legal education, yet Shamim remained involved in cases for poor people while Chandrapal chose a path towards substantial financial gain. Their common beginning and divergent outcomes form a counterexample to the idea of inevitable moral decline. An education or social setting does not determine one professional destiny. Shamim receives relatively little independent biographical development; his principal function is to embody an ethical alternative within Chandrapal's retrospective account. That limitation does not make the contrast unimportant. It allows the narrative to locate a moment of choice within a life otherwise presented largely through its harmful present. The comparison should be read as a narrative counterpoint, not as a fully documented parallel biography.

The Wrong River Name at Broome's Old Warehouse

Edward Broome visits an old company warehouse and discovers that the name of an Indian river is wrongly written on a project plaque. The incident creates a contrast between polished international speeches about institutional prestige and a failure to respect the name of the local place. Mispronunciation and misspelling become signs of distance from the lived geography of those affected by a project. An isolated spelling error, however, cannot establish a whole system of exploitation. Within the novel it acquires meaning through its proximity to the many earlier accusations, images and memories associated with the bridge. Broome's

reaction offers a possible moment of recognition; whether he intends actual correction and accountability has to be tested by his subsequent actions. One corrected inscription cannot substitute for that test.

Raghav and Chandrapal's Shared Silence

Chandrapal telephones Raghav and says that he is remembering; Raghav replies that he is too. Neither asks forgiveness, surrenders, nor provides a factual account of the network's operations. Yet the very small exchange establishes a silence different from the deliberate secrecy of earlier chapters. Something unwelcome has become present within memory. The narrator does not make this subdued contact the triumphant announcement of moral salvation. It constitutes, at most, a first condition of inward change: the willingness to acknowledge that the past persists. The sparseness of the conversation is important because so many other scenes in this cycle make their ethical propositions explicit. Here the unspoken material remains heavier than the characters' words, and no completed transformation is claimed.

The School Turns Its Attention towards the Villains

Devika explains the beginnings of Chandrapal's fraud to the children, while Aruni and Gop gather clues about the earlier lives of the antagonists. The purpose of civic education consequently expands beyond preventing another deception. It now includes studying how a person acquired power and entered a history of exploitation. The shift has an evident ethical risk: pupils might be encouraged to treat an accused person's background as proof of a particular crime, or to confuse the differing roles of organisers, intermediaries and people used by the network. The narrative remains alert to the fact that documents do not all possess the same evidentiary weight. To teach the origins of wrongdoing responsibly requires the separation of what is known, what is inferred and what still needs investigation. This distinction makes the new curriculum an inquiry rather than an exercise in denunciation.

The Pause in Play during the Eighth Breath

There is no ghost-kabaddi in Channa Grove that night. The children suspend their game and undertake study instead. This interruption is a significant change in the ceremony. In earlier chapters the breath of the game seemed to continue through successive confrontations; here a pause becomes an instrument for gathering information. Narrative pace slows from magical competition to the quieter activity of searching for sources. The reader is invited to discover that courage in a story of justice need not always appear as a noisy event, a dramatic encounter or a public accusation. It can also take the form of patient research. The eighth breath is therefore

not an absence of action but a deliberate alteration in the kind of action the story values.

Preserving the Enemy's Face: An Ethical Limit

Ananya says that one should also understand the home of the person one wishes to defeat; otherwise victory itself might become another crime. The statement identifies a danger that arises when power changes hands: the victorious side may treat the adversary as completely devoid of human identity. It is not merely a general prohibition on retaliation but a warning against reproducing the dehumanisation previously directed at the victims. This sympathetic method must nevertheless neither weaken the victims' claims to justice nor compromise their safety and privacy. Knowing an enemy's home is not a request to forgive without accountability. The narrative's ethical ambition is to keep historical investigation and responsibility together, without allowing humane attention to the accused to erase the circumstances of those who suffered harm.

Overall Assessment

The achievement of "Three Pebbles" is its transformation of the antagonists' psychological distress into a structured search for antecedent histories. The father's old lane, Shamim's alternative choice, Raghav's domestic emptiness, Broome's misnamed river and Gop's incomplete documents supply different entrances into the history of exploitation. A stylistic risk remains: almost every character's past appears to yield a readily intelligible lesson about the value of a name. The eighth breath's silence and the brief exchange between Raghav and Chandrapal, however, resist an excessively satisfying conclusion. No premature forgiveness is demanded and no complete repentance is announced. The chapter's critical value lies in widening the inquiry without resolving it by imaginative assertions unsupported by its own documents.

Critical Section 139 | Original Chapter 38 — The Pronunciation of Names

A New Requirement after Writing: Reading Aloud

Following the eighth breath, play is suspended for two days in Channa Grove. The children have already written the archive of names, yet Burhba the ghost insists upon another task: pronouncing them. The pause exposes the difference between a written register and the voices of those to whom it refers. Script alone does not preserve a person's entire memory; calling a person correctly is itself a social act. The warning that misreading a name is like killing again is a powerful rhetorical expression, but it should not become an eternal moral condemnation of every ordinary difference in dialect or pronunciation. It is directed specifically against the distortion of names through which people have been erased. Correct reading has an ethical purpose that exceeds grammatical correctness.

The Rule of Three Leaves: Home, Death and Humiliation

The gathering develops a new rule for reading names: a person's home, death and humiliation should be read alongside the name. This triad is not identical to the earlier three pebbles of "home, fear and dream." The previous set concerns the inner lives of people and families; the later one is directed towards death, historical erasure and social dishonour. The archive's purpose consequently expands, but the stability of its method becomes questionable. Has one oral instruction been revised, or is a second register being developed for a different purpose? The text does not explicitly distinguish the two. The critic must not silently fuse them into a fixed, wholly coherent schema. Their coexistence demonstrates both the growing ambitions of remembrance and the unsettled form of its rules.

Bhola Nat's Name and the Arrival of His Sister

After Bhola Nat's name is correctly pronounced, a shadowy woman appears at the outer edge of the grove and says that she is his sister. The magical idea that a road becomes visible when a name is spoken now acquires a dramatic image. Information about the family of this labourer from a distant district had been lost; oral remembrance becomes the impetus for recovering a connection. Nevertheless, the shadowy figure's arrival belongs to the narrative's folk-magical register and cannot be treated as a completed documentary verification of kinship. Her claim begins another search. The episode is important precisely because it opposes the finality of administrative oblivion with the possibility of further inquiry. Pronunciation opens the road; it does not itself establish everything awaiting discovery at its end.

"Sarayu Mahato, Male, Absent": The Violence of the Record

In this chapter, the official entry for Sarayu reads "Sarayu Mahato, male, absent," while the children read the name as belonging to a woman labourer. Earlier chapters repeatedly used "Sarayu Devi." The problem cannot simply be dismissed as a variation in an honorific: "Mahato" and "Devi" are different name forms and the official entry contains an apparent error of gender. These could reflect differences between a familiar name, marital identification and the official register, but the source does not establish such a relationship. The review leaves the discrepancy open. The episode's ethical centre is the way misgendering within a document can make a woman worker disappear, although the biography and name-form continuity remain matters for source-based examination rather than speculative repair.

Devika's Difficult Voice while Reading Ujjwal's Name

Devika speaks her brother's full name, identifies him in his relationships as a son and a student, and recalls the suffering associated with screen-based fraud. Her voice threatens to break; Ananya takes her hand. The children's silence replaces applause. The public ceremony of pronouncing names therefore does not suppress the particularity of a family's grief. Earlier descriptions of Ujjwal's death have differed—the riverbank scene, the image of a hanging body and the rope image in a dream cannot be reconciled simply by this later act of naming. The present chapter remains at the level of emotional remembrance. Its force comes from permitting Devika's voice to falter without implying that collective ritual has settled the unresolved narrative details or restored her brother's life.

Munna's Living Name and the Bank Seal

When Munna Paswan's name is read, a bank seal appears on the leaf and then disappears. Munna is alive. His inclusion does not mean that he has been entered among the dead; it signifies the social reidentification of a person demeaned through the use of his account by a financial network. Yet if death is an indispensable item under the rule of three leaves, how is the history of a living victim to be classified? Meera subsequently speaks of protecting the names of the living as well. This expansion makes a distinction between records of deceased persons and records for the protection of living victims all the more necessary. The ceremony's compassion does not eliminate the archival need for different categories, purposes and rules of disclosure.

From "Home Unknown" to "Home Yet to Be Found"

Batuknath writes "home unknown" beside Bhola Nat's name, but the magical paper darkens. He changes the phrase to "home yet to be found."

The revision is extraordinarily subtle and important. The first formulation treats ignorance as a settled condition; the second acknowledges an unfinished task of investigation. It refuses to fill a gap by claiming knowledge that no one possesses. The author's magical paper responds as a moral editor, but the lesson it dramatises depends in the real world upon human labour: inquiry, identification and verification. A blank or uncertain entry can indicate a responsibility to keep searching rather than an excuse to fabricate an answer. This small correction is one of the chapter's strongest narratological achievements.

Chandrapal and the Chain of Causes behind Ujjwal's Death

Chandrapal writes "suicide," but the screen asks further questions about causes, loans, games and the network controlling those games. This sequence shifts the discussion from a narrowed attribution to one person's decision towards the possible economic and digital pressures surrounding the death. The original novel has already presented mutually conflicting images of the death scene; writing "suicide" does not resolve those discrepancies or provide a completed medical or judicial determination. Chandrapal's eventual admission concerning his network is part of the character's inward acknowledgement. A statement by an implicated character may reveal a moral crisis without constituting an independently verified account of each link in an alleged chain of responsibility. The narrative thus expands causal inquiry while retaining factual uncertainty.

Raghav's "The Name Was Stolen"

Raghav revises the description of Munna's identity from the terminology of a "mule account" towards the statement "the name was stolen." This is a meaningful progression in writing. An economic category comes first; then the issue of consent emerges; finally the language of an appropriated identity becomes possible. The character's vocabulary gradually moves from a functional description of a financial instrument towards a recognition of the person used through it. But Munna's actual consent, his signatures and the extent of his knowledge of the network cannot be settled finally without documentary investigation. Raghav's wording remains one perspective within a disputed source situation. The chapter's distinction is that a change in moral language has begun, not that the case has been legally adjudicated.

Hulasi's Objection to Accounts of Her Death

Hulasi asks to have her own name read before the assembly. Accounts of suicide, love, sin and the well have circulated about her; she says that her fall into the well was accidental and that the allegation of suicide affected her entitlement to funeral rites. The scene grants a dead woman an

extraordinary opportunity to contest the story told about her. Her voice challenges communal slander and the appropriation of her death by interpretations she did not authorise. At the same time, supernatural testimony must be distinguished from external historical verification. The narrative's artistic accomplishment is the appearance of Hulasi's clear first-person counterstatement among the many public versions of her life. Its importance lies in the question of who has the right to narrate her death.

The Blurring of the Rogues' Signatures

Burhba's rule is that those who dishonour the names of others will lose mastery over their own names. Signatures on documents associated with Batuknath, Chandrapal, Raghav and Lau become indistinct. This is a reversal of the violence the antagonists have practised: instead of imposing bodily punishment, the magical court disturbs the stability of a signature. The disappearance or alteration of letters in the external documents is an imaginative act within the fiction, not evidence that actual official records have undergone such changes. The scene pictures an ethical consequence for the deliberate manipulation of others' identities. Its form depends upon the novel's magical realism, and the critic should resist mistaking the poetic punishment for a verifiable legal process.

Translation, Privacy and the Archive's Shared Difficulty

Soumya carries the rule of the three leaves into the people's language, Nishant listens to a child's reminder that a telephone number is not a person's name, and Meera wants identities appropriated without consent to be restored with dignity. These tasks reveal a further problem: publicly naming a living person subjected to blackmail could once again threaten that person's privacy. Protecting a name and exposing a name are not the same act. The archive must apply the concern for consent articulated in the earlier pledge of privacy to its own procedures. Good intentions cannot authorise unlimited disclosure. Technical descriptions, social memory and a person's right to control intimate information must be kept in relationship, while their differences remain visible.

Loth Becomes a Corrector of Lines

After the night's name-reading, the tired children fall asleep in the grove. Loth, who was once only a spectator, begins moving his mouth gently whenever somebody makes a mistake, gradually assuming the role of a corrector. This small extension of the character's function is particularly interesting. Knowledge possessed by the spirits is no longer confined to a spectacular supernatural hearing; it is shared through the minute work of improving a pronunciation. The magical community thus becomes a collaborator in the village school. The episode contributes to the long

development of a minor character and shifts the narrative once more towards social practice. Correction is not a grand act of vengeance but an attentive form of listening.

Overall Position of the Section

"The Pronunciation of Names" extends far beyond technical accuracy of speech. It is concerned with linguistic responsibility, the misrecording of a woman worker, respect for living victims, Hulasi's own account of her death and the recovery of lost family connections. The strongest moments are Hulasi's resistance to the narratives imposed upon her and the modest revision from "home unknown" to "home yet to be found." Its limitations are the sometimes categorical ethical sayings, the repeated pattern of magical punishment and the unclear continuity of Sarayu's names. The chapter should therefore be read not as the uncomplicated success of a single principle but as another entry into a difficult history of conflicting sources, contested names and continuing inquiry.

Critical Section 140 | Original Chapter 39 — The Peace of the Seed

The Slow Transition from the Ninth to the Tenth Breath

"The Peace of the Seed" begins in the stillness following the exhaustion of reading names. This is not the peace of a permanent resolution; it is the interval in which one waits for something buried in the soil to germinate. The dead have been named, but their homes, labour and dreams have not yet been recovered in their full dimensions. The narrator constructs a still slower experience of time in preparation for another set of questions. The rapid breath of the earlier game gives way to the invisible biological time of sowing. As the rate of outward action diminishes, the prospect of future action increases. This alteration of pace is an important element of narrative design: the pause contains potential rather than simply marking the cessation of conflict.

Ananya's "If Fear Is Kept Secret, It Becomes a Trade"

In the school, Devika teaches a short rule about the commercial exploitation of fear. Asked by a child to clarify it, she explains that telling someone about fear does not make the fear vanish immediately, but it may alter who controls it. The answer possesses greater psychological restraint than many of the more slogan-like declarations in earlier chapters. The narrative acknowledges that the experience of fear may continue long after somebody has begun to resist. The victim is not ordered to become instantly fearless; the possibility offered is that of finding a trusted relationship. The social and educational poetry of the novel here acquires a more practical and exact sense. Speaking does not abolish vulnerability, but it may help prevent secrecy from becoming an instrument of control.

Seeds from SIM Cards: From Erasure to Germination

SIM cards in Raghav's room split and become small seeds; from each seed grows a leaf bearing an incomplete name. The attempt to make technical information disappear is transformed into an image of natural regeneration. This marvel is not a realistic procedure for digital recovery, nor can it be cited as proof that deleted data have been restored. Its narrative meaning is the resistance of social memory to the fantasy of total erasure. The names remain incomplete even after the leaves have grown. Germination is therefore not equivalent to a finished harvest or a completed investigation. The image joins the previous plant imagery to the modern apparatus of communication, giving the story a way to picture survival without pretending that the remaining work has already been done.

The First Maithili Sentence of Ira's Paper

In the Harvard library, Ira works on a paper about ethical lectures and the resistance of names. Although she intends to write in English, her first sentence appears in Maithili. This linguistic doubleness mirrors an important division within the novel. An intellectual platform outside the homeland is addressed through the sound of the village's own language. Ira's action is an assertion of narrative agency, not merely a passive return to inherited identity. Yet protecting the original language and claiming that translation is impossible are different propositions. Her refusal to translate a particular phrase is a moment of literary independence; it should not be mistaken for a general prohibition on translation between languages. The choice of an opening sentence gives the local voice a place within international discourse without erasing the practical need for bilingual understanding.

Soumya and Ramaiyya's Reading in the People's Language

Soumya writes human consequences alongside administrative terms such as financial irregularity, unauthorised labour and supply expenditure. Ramaiyya Subramanyam participates in this work of translation. Language here concerns public access to meaning rather than stylistic elegance alone. An official expression might appear precise while leaving the actual suffering concealed from those most affected. At the same time, translation must not sacrifice a technical term's legal meaning simply to produce an immediately affecting popular sentence. Preserving the original expression alongside an explanation in accessible language gives readers the opportunity to test both. The work of the two women thus occupies an intermediary position: they do not replace expert vocabulary with sentiment; they try to make its social implications open to scrutiny.

Gop's Dissatisfaction: The Bills Remain

Gop recognises that the name archive, the school and the pledge of privacy are progressing, while Broome, Lau, Batuknath, Chandrapal and Raghav remain in relatively secure positions within their respective businesses. The ghost's injunction to send water into the crocodile's burrow becomes a metaphor for a further stage of resistance. Here “water” means the spread of knowledge, not physical retaliation or the infliction of personal harm. At a moment when the novel could easily celebrate community success and stop asking questions, the narrator restores attention to the persistence of structural power. The struggle remains asymmetrical. Effective local teaching does not prove the destruction of a transnational network, and the story's dissatisfaction holds open the distance between education and institutional accountability.

The Social Routes of "Water into the Burrow"

The tenth breath's plan is to carry name-reading, discussion of fear, account-checking and critical examination of the language of development into villages, schools, migrant families, court waiting areas, banks and domestic relationships. No single person is appointed as the leader. The existing community school expands into a social network of teaching. The metaphor of water entering the burrow expresses the movement of questions into spaces that had previously seemed protected from them. Still, the geographic ambition of the plan and the actual number of people reached must remain separate. The text provides scenes of action in particular locations, not a verified census of the entire campaign. The narrative achieves scope through an expanding list of social settings, but critical accuracy requires attention to where its events are actually shown.

A New Role-Playing Game: "Catch the Correct Name"

Ananya assigns children the roles of perpetrator, victim, witness and judge in a game. The person acting as the perpetrator distorts a name; the witness corrects it; and the person playing the victim runs again when the right name has been recovered. This is a noteworthy development in the novel's educational use of games. Earlier kabaddi sequences required the recall of erased names, whereas this new exercise asks the players to practise their different responsibilities within a dispute. It makes narrative positions visible through bodily action. Yet acting as a perpetrator is not identical to perpetrating an offence, and completing a role-play does not establish the safety of a real victim. Its achievement is pedagogical: it offers a small, repeatable structure through which children may begin to understand the relation between testimony, naming and responsibility.

Hulasi's Right to a Childhood

Hulasi explains that names imposed upon her—suicide, sin and ill omen—had made her lose the memory of her childhood. Hearing her own name correctly allows childhood to return. This unexpected turn means that the ghostly figure is no longer only a symbol of suffering at the moment of death. She is recalled as a person who had once lived through the ordinary fullness of childhood. The episode refines the self-narration offered in Chapter 38. Resistance to stigma acquires a quieter emotional dimension: it is not enough to correct an account of the death if the entire life before the death remains concealed. The figure of a dead woman seeking freedom from social dishonour is joined to the small, intimate recollection of someone she once was.

Batuknath's Father: A New Geographical Difference

Here Batuknath remembers his father writing the names of poor people outside a court in a small town in Kerala. Chapter 37 had referred instead to an old lane in Madras. The source does not explain how the places are connected, whether the family moved, or whether separate stages of life are involved. The critic must not supply a speculative itinerary. These may be different locations of memory or evidence of an internal inconsistency. The basic moral proposition remains comparable: the name of a poor person deserves the same seriousness as that person's land. But continuity of sentiment does not establish continuity of the geographical details. A source-faithful reading should retain both the meaningful recollection and the unresolved difference of place.

Chandrapal's Offline Printer

Chandrapal prepares a defamation claim against the public education campaign, but unexpected writing concerning names appears on an offline printer. He blames programming; an employee replies that the machine is not connected to the network. The event undermines the character's confidence in familiar technical explanations. The narrator returns to the apparatus of magical realism, but the repeated production of self-writing machines and documents has a limitation: after many chapters, the same mechanism can become predictable. More importantly, Chandrapal's preparation of another retaliatory case shows that his ethical transformation is still incomplete. A disturbing supernatural experience has not stopped him from planning action against the school. The scene retains the distance between being frightened and acting responsibly.

The Bank Clerk's Red Pencil

A bank employee first defends the account opened for Munna by citing the rules. A child asks whether the rules ever saw the human being behind the account. The clerk returns home, opens the register and marks three suspicious accounts in red pencil. This modest action represents a significant formal change in the novel: instead of a self-writing supernatural document, an ordinary institutional employee responds to a question by conducting a limited check. The three marked accounts are neither final criminal convictions nor a completed audit. They are indications that further inquiry is required. Nevertheless, this is one of the first examples of moral resistance taking shape through a small act of doubt inside the institution itself. Its credibility comes from its scale and incompleteness.

The Symbolic Meal of the Dead and the Living

On the night of the tenth breath there is a symbolic meal rather than a court. Every household brings rice, salt, water and a leaf from the register of names. Devika places salt by Ujjwal's leaf, Meera a lamp, Soumya a translation, Ira an unstamped card, Gop a copy of a document and Ananya chalk. The arrangement gives material form to the novel's collective voice. No literal rice meal is consumed; the assembly is an acknowledgement of shared remembrance. Each object identifies a different form of labour, preventing the success of the community from being attributed to a single hero. The scene's emotional force depends upon the distinct meanings of the objects being placed together without losing their separate histories.

"Now": An Imperative of Unfinished Peace

At dawn, Ananya reads only "now" in a drop of dew. Past remembrance and future hope are thereby brought into the ethical work of the present. Read a name, speak about fear, examine an account, teach a child, visit a dead worker's home: these acts become a renewed collective beginning. The final lines do not show kabaddi as having fully restarted, but neither is it definitively suspended. The breath remains held. "The Peace of the Seed" thus describes an intensely expectant interval rather than the resolution of the conflict. The novel's structural strength is this tension between stillness and germination. Its weakness is the recurrent excess of explicit injunctions, which can diminish the openness of an event when its ethical interpretation has already been announced.

Inter-sectional Conclusion: The Narratological Design of Chapters 32–39

These eight chapters organise their material into successive "breaths" of an extended game. The third kabaddi brings dead people, living children and the minds of the rogues into three narrative teams. The fourth breath tests the pronunciation of names; the fifth requires the full name; the sixth takes the action to a threshold; the seventh turns to home, fear and dreams; the eighth investigates antecedent lives through the pebbles; the ninth attends to correct pronunciation; and the tenth develops the peace of the seed and the circulation of knowledge in the present. This is the sequence, but not the closure of a single straight line. Play is repeatedly suspended, resumed and given new rules. The novel converts the original ghost-kabaddi into a form of social education that can continue beyond the grove.

The strongest episodes are those in which human action carries weight independently of a supernatural pronouncement: Munna's mother pulling her scarf away from Raghav's attempt at apology; Batuknath replacing

"home unknown" with "home yet to be found"; Hulasi's objection to the accusation of suicide; the inquiry into the earlier lives of oppressors through three pebbles; and the bank clerk marking three suspect accounts in red. Here justice is neither the descent of a lofty maxim nor the instant victory of a magical court. It is incomplete investigation and limited practical intervention. Gop's insistence that old receipts and tickets are not complete proof lends particular credibility to the archive.

Four tensions in the original must remain visible. First, the relationship among "Sarayu Devi," "Sarayu Mahato" and the official entry "male, absent" is not established. Second, the geography of Batuknath's journeys and memories of his father—Madras and Kerala—has not been arranged into a verified chronology. Third, Ujjwal's death is represented through riverbank and later rope imagery without an explicit reconciliation. Fourth, the rule of "home, fear and dream" in Chapter 36 becomes "home, death and humiliation" in Chapter 38, without a clear explanation of whether the schemes serve different purposes. Hulasi's first-person rejection of the suicide account is significant testimony within the narrative, not an external judicial certificate.

A formal difficulty persists as well. Leaves that write themselves, letters appearing on printers, cracks in glass and magically changing orders repeatedly provide similar moral answers. The reader can sometimes predict that the exploiters' rationalisations will be defeated. The narrative becomes more uncertain and alive when the response is supplied instead by a bereaved family, an ordinary bank employee or a child's difficult question. Neither declaring every inconsistency a deliberately perfect principle nor dismissing every recurrence as a mere error is adequate. The analysis rests on separate attention to narrative time, focalisation, place, voice, folk-song, magical realism and conflicting sources; it does not depend on a Navya-Nyaya examination of proof.

Critical Section 141 | Original Chapter 40 — Letters of Dew

The Transition from the Tenth to the Eleventh Breath

The final word “now” in “The Peace of the Seed” initiates the eleventh breath in “Letters of Dew.” The narrator considers the earlier recitation of names incomplete and introduces another requirement: a dead person's name must be accompanied by the person's life, food, fear, journey and unfinished needs. This is more than another turn in cyclical time; it changes the class of material from which narration is made. A list becomes an arrangement of everyday objects. As the children read the dew, their palms become wet, intensifying the demand for touch after an earlier emphasis on listening. The letters of dew are not an automatically verified history. They are a magical medium for the social memory of the village, and the characters' task of examining material evidence remains distinct from their evocative experience.

The Three-Layered Archive: Name, Object, Story

Ananya proposes associating an object with every name. Old letters, hospital slips, bank passbook copies, bus tickets, the cracked glass of Ujjwal's phone and a document shared voluntarily by Meera enter the grove. Names rest on leaves, objects on the earth and stories in the air. This three-part arrangement is an important formal invention. The death list composed of numbers and entries acquires a new series of everyday experiences. The material objects retain distinct sources, however. A documented copy, an oral recollection and a supernatural manifestation cannot be given identical evidentiary status. The triadic arrangement permits a fuller representation of human lives while requiring the critic to say what each kind of object actually supports. Its strength lies in a plurality of media, not an undifferentiated claim that all forms of testimony prove the same facts.

Bhola Nat's Tiffin and the Taste of Labour

The account of Bhola Nat's tiffin brings the smell of rice, salt and onion into the story. A magical scene suggests that the ghost's hunger diminishes. The dead labourer is thus no longer only an entry in a record of industrial accidents; he had habits of eating and lived within a daily routine of work. The communal rhythm of the songs becomes connected to personal memory through a kitchen object. To say that his hunger is “half relieved” is a folk-magical expression for a partial recovery of recognition, not a literal delivery of nourishment to the dead. The tiffin has more than sentimental value: it brings the material conditions of labour, food and resources into the account. It resists a purely abstract

celebration of the name by asking what the named person carried and needed.

Sarayu Mahato, Kamli and the Contradiction in Family Identification

In Chapter 40, Kamli, described as Sarayu Mahato's daughter, brings a broken anklet. She says that her "Babuji" went to the bridge, had promised to repair her mother's anklet, and did not return. Yet only one chapter earlier, Sarayu Mahato was read as a woman labourer; previous chapters had also depicted "Sarayu Devi" as a woman working at the bridge. Here the name "Sarayu Mahato" identifies a father. This is not merely a difference of honorific. The source does not explain whether two people share the name Sarayu or whether a single character's gender and family identity have changed. The criticism must accept the emotional force of Kamli's anklet while leaving this genuine inconsistency in identity unresolved.

How Far the Anklet Raises the Dead

When Kamli's anklet touches the soil, it rings; the narration associates its sound with an image of Sarayu Mahato rising an inch above a watery grave. The author chooses the extremely small measure of "one inch" rather than describing a complete restoration of life or an all-powerful compensation for bereavement. The miniature scale is apt: a family's condition is not transformed in a moment. The gentle sound of the ornament gives the abstract recognition of a name an intimate domestic voice. At the same time, the discrepancy concerning Kamli's relation to Sarayu leaves factual uncertainty alongside the emotional strength of the scene. The physical resonance of the anklet is carefully localised, but its magical consequence must not be used to conceal contradictory character information.

Munna's Account: Different Owners of Name and Control

Munna Paswan explains in the school that the account stood in his name while fear and instructions remained under someone else's control. The bank clerk's scrutiny has expanded from three marked accounts to fourteen. This provides a specific measure of progress within the story, but fourteen marked accounts are still the product of preliminary institutional caution, not fourteen final convictions. The difference between the named account holder and the person actually directing transactions acquires force through Munna's testimony. The earlier dehumanising category of the mule account becomes a question about how particular people are recruited, pressured and represented in records. Names on accounts matter, but their appearance alone does not establish equal knowledge, initiative or liability among all account holders.

Batuknath's Slip Bearing His Father's Names

Batuknath comes to the grove carrying his father's old slip of names instead of the order proclaiming his victory. His wish to read his father first marks an important change in self-understanding. The obligation imposed by the archive now extends beyond the dead and exploited to the lineage of someone associated with their exploitation. Yet the time relationship among Batuknath's visits to the village in Chapters 23, 26, 35 and 40 remains insufficiently transparent. There may have been repeated journeys, but their dates, returns and transitions are not described well enough to establish a definite itinerary. The reading must preserve the new emotional significance of the father's slip without claiming that the chronology has thereby become coherent.

Chandrapal's Counter-Propaganda and the Changing Headline

Chandrapal approaches an information agency, consultants and publicity managers with a plan to portray the name archive as a foreign conspiracy. The title of his press document magically changes into a demand: “Read Me Too.” The scene joins popular resistance to satire. An actor intent on managing public images loses control of his own words. Yet the political effect of this proposal has not been determined in the chapter. The text shows the plan and the reversal of the headline, not a detailed account of a broad public response or a completed institutional defeat. Interpreting the magical change as the total failure of the publicity campaign would outrun the narrated evidence. The contrast works best as an image of threatened representational power.

Lau's Salt and Broome's Tiffin

A grain of salt on Lau's glass table in Hong Kong, and the image of Bhola Nat's tiffin on Broome's speaking platform, bring household labour into the abstract language of international profitability. Salt points both towards maritime commerce and the sweat of workers. The tiffin brings the recollection of a death associated with ordinary food into the setting of an elite conference. The scene is brief parallel editing through magical realism. Neither object should be treated as a photograph with a separately verified provenance. Their analytical function is to disturb the self-contained prestige of the characters' public settings by introducing the material lives that those settings have overlooked. The juxtaposition retains distinct sensory meanings even while it joins the two sites through memory.

Meera's Limit on Voluntary Sharing

Meera clarifies that an object offered by one's own choice can become part of collective remembrance, whereas a private object taken for the purpose

of intimidation constitutes violence. The distinction draws an indispensable boundary around the expanding archive of names and objects. If public remembrance required every victim to reveal all intimate details, the practice would threaten to inflict the very harm against which it was founded. Meera's intervention is therefore an internal criticism of the campaign's possible excesses. The goal of popular education does not require every private love letter to be read aloud. The individual must retain control over whether and how personal material is shared. Memory has moral value only when it also respects the agency of the person remembered or heard.

Madhav's Incomplete Name: A Test of the School's Security

A visitor near the market asks where the name archive is kept. Ananya does not punish him; she invites him to sit in the school and write his complete name. He stops after "Madhav." The visitor is presented as a possible hired investigator, but the reader is not supplied independent proof of every ulterior motive attributed to him. The children's response represents collective vigilance without physical violence or revenge. Four supernatural marks left by his footsteps provide a moral image of the visitor's intention. The exercise in naming now acquires a protective dimension. But suspicion, magical imagery and an incomplete answer must not be conflated with a verified account of his actions. The school is learning caution while trying to preserve its refusal of indiscriminate punishment.

Panidubbi's Nail, SIM Card and Flower

Three objects fall from Panidubbi's hair: a rusted nail, a broken SIM card and a dried coconut flower. Together they connect bridge construction, digital exploitation and the vegetation of the village. Earlier, the many guises of the crocodile brought these spheres under one expansive metaphor. Here each object retains its particular materiality. A nail belongs to iron, a SIM card to electronic communication, a flower to organic life. This concrete differentiation prevents the novel's breadth from becoming solely an abstract statement about oppression. Objects acquire imaginative force precisely because they do not lose the properties of the worlds from which they originate. The trio creates unity through juxtaposition rather than asserting that all the processes represented have identical causes.

Gop and Satyavrat's Revision of Words

Gop now sees the security of truth not only in copies but in its social use. Satyavrat writes an elaborate expression resembling "the democratisation of evidence," crosses it out, and substitutes the simpler "the evidence

reached people's homes." These changes are also the author's reflection upon language. In place of a specialised formulation comes a sentence whose meaning can be grasped directly in ordinary life. Nevertheless, legal admissibility and social credibility cannot simply be equated. The sources of names, documents, oral narratives and original objects still require examination. The revision of vocabulary is valuable because it makes a problem accessible; it does not abolish the distinctions needed to investigate that problem responsibly.

The Eleventh Breath Ends: Objects Take Their Own Journeys

By the close of the chapter, the practice of associating names with objects moves beyond the grove into homes, banks, intimate relationships and the lives of students abroad. The "now" of Chapter 39 has become an unfolding social experiment. Once again the narrator declares that the story is not finished. This recurrence risks becoming formulaic, yet it also constitutes a consistent method of work. Among the chapter's achievements are Meera's boundary of consent, Munna's account of the separation of account ownership from operational control, and the intimate significance of Kamli's anklet. The most serious source problem remains the explicit conflict between Sarayu Mahato's description as a woman and as Kamli's father. The magic of dew and objects cannot legitimately be used to dissolve that contradiction.

Critical Section 142 | Original Chapter 41 — The Boat of Names

From the Place of Objects to the Lines of a Journey

After the gathering of names and objects into a comparatively fixed archive, “The Boat of Names” asks where a dead person began a journey, by what route the person travelled, where the journey was obstructed and where the family now lives. In Channa Grove, rice, turmeric, salt, water, a red pencil and an empty map are used to construct routes from remembered experience. The archive becomes a spatial narrative. Chains of social causation are not confined to the lines of a file: they are represented as the places through which human feet have moved. The title provides a riverine metaphor, although much of the chapter concerns travel over land. The boat is a method of carrying memory between places, not merely an object to be seen upon water.

Bhola Nat's Route Marked in Rice

The children trace Bhola Nat's route from home to the fields, the contracting camp and the bridge pier, using grains of rice, turmeric, salt and water. Food signifies daily livelihood; turmeric connects the drawing to the soil of the fields; salt recalls labouring sweat; and water points towards the place of the construction accident. The materials give the story both texture and a route. Yet the precise sequence of locations and times cannot be independently established from a line drawn upon earth. This is a direction for investigation built out of local remembrance. Its details would require comparison with measurements, labourers' statements and other records. The critical distinction is between a meaningful reconstruction of experience and a completed verification of its geographical itinerary.

Sarayu Mahato's Tiffin and the Indispensable Question of Gender

In Chapter 41, Sarayu Mahato's tiffin traces a route through the workers' lines, a contractor's warehouse and the bridge's left pier. The text also mentions a piece of cloth belonging to Sarayu's wife. This description further supports the presentation of Sarayu as a man and father in Chapter 40, whereas Chapter 38 described Sarayu Mahato as a woman labourer. The source does not establish whether two people happen to share the name or whether the gender of one character has changed from one account to another. The criticism cannot manufacture a seamless biography to remove the discrepancy. The tiffin's route has a narrative function, but the identity and relationships of its owner remain among the most important textual questions raised by this sequence.

From Ujjwal's House to the Mobile Shop

Devika connects Ujjwal's home, school, mobile shop, first gaming win, debt and fear of a counterfeit digital arrest by placing separate signs upon the soil. Unlike the route of a bridge labourer, the digital pathway concludes with the image of a roof. This does not reconcile the already noted differences between the riverbank and hanging-body depictions of Ujjwal's death. Rather, the diagram makes visible an extended sequence of social and psychological pressures. The route of fear should not conceal the uncertainty surrounding the actual death scene. Devika's narration is particularly effective because it gives a bereaved sister the authority to trace relationships among events without compelling the critic to convert her grief into a final legal determination of cause.

Nishant's Three Bowls

Nishant places three bowls upon the earth, labelled “name,” “account” and “fear,” and asks Munna who controlled the name entered upon his account. The bowls are practical tools of financial education. They give a visual form to the differences among identity, resources and coercion for an audience that may not be able to follow an abstract account of financial transactions. Objects become the means through which one character helps others to ask precise questions. Their material simplicity is part of the pedagogical achievement. Yet the demonstration is not a technically complete model of banking regulation or the entire account network. Its purpose is to begin inquiry, not replace a regulator's or court's detailed examination. The story values understandable questions while preserving the need for further evidence.

The Roots of Raghav's Messages

Raghav's sprouts become wires connecting phones from which messages have been erased. He breaks a phone, but a half-sentence emerges from a leaf. This is another magical transformation of technology into plant life; its new function is the construction of a route. Information moves imaginatively from one telephone to another and from one account towards a third. Secret pathways of profit are represented as paths recoverable in popular memory. Since the action is supernatural, it cannot be treated as a demonstration of an actual method for recovering deleted data. The episode's value lies in its depiction of relationships that secrecy was intended to hide. The repeated device of magical reappearance nevertheless risks familiarity when so many earlier screens and documents have answered exploitation in a similar fashion.

Chandrapal's "Route" Folder

Chandrapal opens a computer folder labelled "Route." Instead of the expected account books, he sees the bowls used in the village's lesson. The private screen at the economic centre now displays the objects of community education. This is a reversal of viewpoint: an arrangement intended to be controlled by Chandrapal presents him with an image of the people learning to question that control. He refuses to accept the transformation as a digital event. His response discloses a central feature of his psychology: he finds it intolerable when the meaning of an object lies beyond the operation of a system he expects to command. Yet the scene also illustrates the formal risk of the novel's increasingly familiar screen miracles. The symbolic inversion is effective without becoming evidence of a technical intrusion.

The Journey of Stolen Private Material

Meera requests that the route taken by a photograph be read as a sequence of trust, telephone, server, threat and silence. This is not a conventional geographical map. It is the movement of personal material after consent has been violated. Soumya prepares accessible explanations of expressions such as "leak," "content" and "blackmail." Translation here restores the recognisability of a victim's experience without eliminating the need for exact technical meaning. A further limit follows from Meera's earlier chapters: publicly tracing the path of intimate material must not involve revealing the material itself without her permission. The narrative's concern with routes cannot justify a repetition of the original disclosure. The person whose privacy was invaded retains authority over what may be shown.

"A Monday in Bhadon": The Ethical Place of Partial Memory

An elderly woman cannot remember the full route of her son, who died at the bridge. She remembers only "a Monday in Bhadon." A child places rice upon that small fragment of recollection. Through Burhba, the narrative teaches respect for incomplete knowledge. This is a particularly important formal principle for criticism based on sources: where a date is uncertain or an event is unknown, the fragment should be marked as a fragment, not supplied with invented details. An unfinished route can be treated with compassion without converting compassion into a substitute for evidence. The episode provides an alternative to the novel's occasional insistence that every name and journey will somehow reveal its whole truth. It allows an unknown part of a life to remain unknown.

Gop's Glowing Empty Space

Beside Gop's seemingly complete spreadsheet, a blank space is left on the earth for those portions of human lives that remain unknown. Hulasi tells the children that not every story can be spoken immediately. This absence becomes an active narrative form: the limits of knowledge are made visible. The admission is especially valuable amid the immense global network mapped elsewhere in the novel. It restrains any easy suggestion that the archive has already captured the whole reality of exploitation. The same rule must apply to literary criticism. If the original text has not described an event, a critic should not create it to achieve the appearance of completeness. Gop's blank place gives material shape to intellectual humility and to the unfinished task of listening.

The Bends in a Route and Preventable Disasters

At the end of each path, the children ask at which bend the harm might have been prevented. For Bhola Nat the question concerns a safety belt; for Sarayu it concerns accurate recording of workers; for Ujjwal it concerns a collective response to the first threat; and for Munna it concerns questioning the inducement to open an account. The narrative presents disasters as situations shaped by human decisions rather than unavoidable destiny. Crucially, the question "Could this have been prevented?" is not intended to shift blame onto the victims. It should direct scrutiny towards the institutions, intermediaries and failures of protection responsible for the circumstances. The distinct bends of the routes keep the inquiry connected to particular lives instead of flattening all suffering into a single general theory.

Satyavrat's Judicial Chain of Causes

Satyavrat Mehta recognises that the chain between cause and consequence in a poor person's life is frequently broken by power. This brings the legal search for causation into dialogue with fragments preserved through popular memory. The state's tendency to disregard oral and familial evidence is part of the narrative's opposition. Yet it would contradict the novel's own insistence upon responsible archives to dismiss the standards of actual investigation as worthless. The depicted task is to search for missing links, not abandon the process of testing them. Satyavrat's awareness supplies a possible bridge between the community's remembered routes and institutional procedure. Neither sphere possesses everything required by itself, and neither can be substituted indiscriminately for the other.

Setting Limits to the Crocodile's Route as Metaphor

River currents, mobile transfers, contractual employment, corporate commerce and legal procedure all receive the shared language of a "route."

This structural affinity helps connect the novel's immense range of times and places. Its risk is equally clear: if every occurrence is described as the result of one universal machinery of exploitation, the historically specific causes of different events disappear. The children's differently coloured lines, their distinct objects and the names of individual people counter that flattening tendency. The metaphor works most effectively when it makes relations visible without asserting the identity of all the processes related. A route can carry a comparative question, but it cannot on its own establish a unified cause.

Conclusion of the Twelfth Breath

"The Boat of Names" develops the story from a fixed archive towards an investigation of routes and movements. Among its strongest scenes are the elder woman's "Monday in Bhadon," the blank space left by Gop, Meera's concern with the movement of private material and Nishant's three bowls. These concrete devices prevent the episode from becoming only a collection of ethical sayings. Although the title gives it the concentrated metaphor of a boat, the boat functions chiefly as a means of carrying memory between homes. The conflict between Sarayu Mahato's masculine familial description and the previous description of Sarayu as a woman labourer remains a major source-based caution. A faithful reading retains the force of the metaphor and the unresolved character history together.

Critical Section 143 | Original Chapter 42 — The Circle of Burden

From the Twelfth Breath's Route to the Thirteenth Breath's Shoulder

Chapter 41 connected the routes taken through the lives of the dead; "The Circle of Burden" asks what moral consequences follow from having constructed those routes. Along a path leading from home, contractor or screen to death or economic loss, whose shoulders should bear responsibility? The narrative thus moves from representing chains of causation towards distributing accountability. The "circle" of the title is more than a round field: it is a structure of questions that gradually returns to the various participants. The principal incidents involve supernatural increases in the weight of objects. Beneath that device lies an inquiry into the limits of moral self-defence. To trace a path is not yet to decide what portion of its consequences belongs to each actor.

The Scales Replaced by a Shoulder

On each page of Batuknath's victorious order, a small image of a shoulder appears in place of the scales of justice. The picture does not simply invalidate legal adjudication; it criticises the professional use of procedure by a character who has paid too little attention to the human cost of adjournments and objections. Scales represent the formal comparison of claims, whereas shoulders evoke effects actually carried by bodies. As the pages become heavier, the file visualises the invisible weight of lives affected by the legal process. Yet this literary example of social and moral burden cannot itself decide the allocation of responsibility in a real court. Its function is to expose an aspect of consequence left outside the character's narrowly procedural understanding of his work.

The File That Cannot Be Lifted Even at One Corner

A servant cannot lift the file. When Batuknath places a hand on it, he imagines the results of numerous adjournments: a woman growing old, a widow continuing to wait, a dead worker's name failing to enter a list. Together these experiences form the file's extraordinary new weight. The heavy order at the threshold in Section 136 is recalled here. The new element is Batuknath's limited ability to lift even one corner. The narrator does not award him an implausibly complete repentance; a small physical action suggests the beginnings of self-knowledge. His contact with the document places the human duration of delay before him. The weight is experienced through magic, but the social circumstances to which it refers remain distinct from the literal properties of paper.

Chandrapal's Account Made of Bricks

The mule accounts on Chandrapal's screen turn into bricks, carrying names such as Munna, Azhar, Pawan, Shakil, Anjali, Rohit and unidentified persons. He presses the delete button, but the bricks fall from the machine onto his desk. Digital transfers become the hard material of house-building. The scene reverses the relation between wealth accumulation and the labouring lives hidden within it: those whose identities helped construct financial profit now appear written upon the building materials. Yet the chapter does not provide separately developed biographies for every name upon a brick. The critic must not imagine complete incidents to populate the list. The transformation embodies the return of concealed identities to the visible basis of a structure created by money and exploitation.

Raghav's Leaf of Stone

Beneath Raghav's pillow appears a leaf made of stone, bearing statements such as “the call was not cut,” “fear was sold” and “grandmother's savings were lost.” The leaf had been an emblem of organic softness; it now possesses the hardness and weight of stone. This change of substance makes the social harm of deleted messages appear more durable than the technical traces meant to be removed. Unlike the wire-roots of Chapter 41, the burden here rests close to the body, beneath the pillow and against the chest. Raghav wishes to throw it away, but the seeming endlessness of the count questions his attempted escape from responsibility. The scene enacts memory as a physical weight, not as an independently recovered transcript of every message.

Salt Ink and Broome's Red Report

Lau's signature pen releases salt water instead of ink, while red lines emerge across Broome's costly report. Two instruments of public control—the pen and the printed report—are transformed by memories of workers' sweat and the costs of death. Commercial language about ethical balance and reputation is surrounded by the social consequences that the documents would prefer to leave outside their boundaries. The images effectively link official representation with bodily labour. Their formal limitation is also evident: a continuing succession of supernatural reactions by screens, printers, glass and documents can become a predictable mechanism. Their critical meaning should therefore be articulated without turning each new visual disturbance into an imagined external finding of guilt.

A "Share" Is Not the Same as the Entire Crime

Children ask each person how much of the burden belongs to them. Rather than assigning every consequence to a single individual, the question seeks recognition of the limits and extent of one's own participation. It is an attempt at practical ethical refinement. Not everyone in the story is entirely a perpetrator, entirely a victim or an omniscient witness. Degrees of knowledge and power matter. Yet the shares are not equal by definition. An exploitative institution, a vulnerable employee, a technical assistant and a bereaved relative cannot have their actions weighed upon one simple scale as though they held the same agency. The novel's symbolic question requires separate institutional investigation when applied to concrete responsibility.

The Self-Notes of Gop, Soumya, Ramaiyya and Devika

Gop admits that he understood the data too late; Soumya that translation was delayed; Ramaiyya that she remained silent unnecessarily; and Devika that she initially misunderstood Ujjwal's fear. The plurality of voices establishes that the movement's principal figures are not beyond criticism of their own conduct. The author counts limits and omissions on the side of resistance as well as the harms attributed to the antagonists. But a bereaved sister's delay in recognising suffering is not a fault of the same order as an organised scheme of exploitation. The practice of self-examination must not become victim-blaming. The value of this episode lies in preserving different responsibilities and degrees of power within a broadly shared willingness to improve future action.

Ananya's Share: "Keep Asking Questions"

Ananya asks what her own share is. Burhba the ghost tells her that her responsibility is to continue asking questions. The child is not burdened with guilt for an offence she has not committed; she is given the capacity and obligation of civic inquiry. Her curiosity at the beginning of the novel's modern sequence is developing into a recurring social method. The responsibility to ask does not mean sharing the criminal responsibility of those whose acts are questioned. It means acknowledging the incompleteness of knowledge and having the courage to direct questions to the persons and institutions best placed to answer them. This is an important distinction within a chapter otherwise filled with images of weight, fault and moral participation.

Satyavrat's Legal Translation of "Burden"

Satyavrat searches for the appropriate legal language: liability, compensation, rehabilitation and corrective orders. None entirely conveys the experience that the community calls a burden. The scene recognises

the necessary difference between legal vocabulary and collective sensation. If the novel treated one folk term as a complete legal solution, its multiple dimensions of reality would be flattened. Instead, the acknowledged insufficiency of several technical terms adds subtlety. Unlike Batuknath's use of procedure to delay and contain questions, Satyavrat seeks language that can hear the affected lives. Nevertheless, his search for a better expression is not a completed institutional judgment. The chapter preserves the difference between linguistic understanding and the work required to secure legal outcomes.

From Objects to Uses

In the next phase of the lesson on burden, the tiffin becomes an aid to discussing food; the helmet to understanding safety; the SIM card to recognising fraud; the passbook to vigilance; a medicine vial to checking supplies; and chalk to children's questioning. This marks an important development of narrative technique. Objects associated with the magical court do not remain inert exhibits in a shrine or museum. They acquire functions in present-day education. The movement from a mourned object to a tool for the living takes many different forms and is dramatically richer than the repeated appearance of miraculous writing. Yet the practical reach of each intervention and its long-term results remain open. The narrative describes possibilities of use, not a fully evaluated programme of social change.

Meera's Group Takes a First Step towards the Police Station

In the circle concerned with privacy, one distressed young woman prepares to visit a police station accompanied by another woman. Her fear has not vanished, but she will not go alone. This is among the novel's most credible scenes of social transformation. Instead of another pledge spoken into a microphone, the characters decide to seek institutional support together. The general rule about collective protection acquires a small but substantial application. The source does not say that a complaint has already been registered or that justice has been obtained. To narrate those outcomes would go beyond the text. The moment's force lies in a specific decision made under conditions of continuing fear, and in companionship that makes action possible.

Gop Reads Ishan's Earlier Note

Gop reads an old note associated with Ishan, whose strange condition of having no shadow remains unresolved. The note insists that disclosure must be given a destination. The earlier inconsistencies concerning Ishan's body and shadow are not explained away by this document, but his voice remains active through the work it demands. Gop understands the

difference between making information visible and creating the conditions through which victims may obtain help. The language of data-based resistance acquires a human destination: assistance, translation and a setting in which people can be heard. This is a useful corrective to the story's fascination with spectacular exposure. The moral completion of a revelation is not necessarily its publicity; it may be its usefulness to a particular person.

The Unfinished Justice of the Thirteenth Breath

At the close, Ananya writes verbs of action beside the objects: feed, protect, listen, prevent and accompany. Batuknath lifts one corner of the file; Chandrapal tries to hide the bricks; Raghav cannot open the door; and Lau lowers the curtain. These divergent responses show different forms of evasion and engagement when responsibility becomes difficult to ignore. The chapter's most important structural choice is that the burden does not disappear entirely. It begins moving towards the homes of those who possess a share of it. Instead of offering a single comprehensive judgment from the court, the narrative leaves a continuing account of social responsibility. Its artistic conclusion is therefore another beginning, but one defined by actions rather than by a claim that moral transformation has been accomplished.

Critical Section 144 | Original Chapter 43 — The Travelling Burden

The fourteenth breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Burden as Messenger: From the Stationary to the Mobile

At the end of the thirteenth breath, a new principle emerged: where those responsible refuse to come forward and shoulder their burden, that burden will travel to their doors. 'The Travelling Burden' distributes this principle across houses, cities and distant countries. The file, brick and stone-leaf of the preceding chapter had been collective emblems; they now appear in a mother's speech, a son's dream and a wife's plate of food. The narrative centre moves from Channa Grove to the rooms of households. Public conflict is carried inward, into the inherited strata of family memory. It is this domestic translation of responsibility—not any new verdict—that gives the chapter its direction.

Hariharan's Mother Calls Him 'Batuk'

The letters on the glass of Batuknath's degree appear strange, but the decisive occurrence is his elderly mother calling him 'Batuk'. Stripped of professional title and standing, the name returns him to a small body with a childhood history. His mother asks how many names he has consumed. Her accusation is the speech of intimate kinship, not an interrogation in court. The immense image of names swallowed by power contracts into a childhood form of address. Because his mother has not spoken the name clearly for a long time, this utterance has an extraordinary, possibly magical force. It does not establish a lasting medical recovery. Its narrative achievement lies in the collision between familial recognition and the social consequences of a lawyer's career.

Chandrapal's Son and His Dream

Chandrapal's son encounters an advertisement for an online game on his phone and recounts a disturbing dream: a dead young man accuses his father's earnings of carrying the smell of a hanging. Chandrapal drops the phone. Economic gain has entered the imagination of an heir who did not personally arrange the transactions. Yet an accusation in a dream is not a verified reconstruction of the death, especially since the narrative has previously offered incompatible accounts of Ujjwal's final moments. The child's fear nevertheless defeats the father's defensive legal vocabulary for an instant. The scene explores the transmission of moral unease rather than asserting hereditary guilt or settling the circumstances of a death.

‘Account Closed’ in Raghav’s Plate

Grains of cooked rice on Raghav’s plate form the words ‘Account Closed’. His wife takes this to refer to household accounts, while he evades her question. A secret commercial code has entered an ordinary shared meal: domestic intimacy collides with criminal concealment. There is, however, a distinct textual problem. Chapter 37 stated that Raghav’s wife had left him; Chapter 43 shows her serving him food without explaining a return or reconciliation. Criticism must preserve this discrepancy instead of inventing a reunion. The rice-script functions as a magical image of accountability, but the unresolved domestic chronology is a separate and real difficulty of character continuity.

The Village’s Name in Lau’s Glass Office

Lau asks his secretary to find Garh Narikela on a map. Among thousands of points, the secretary locates a small luminous place. A seemingly remote village acquires an involuntary presence inside a transnational financial empire. This develops the earlier image of salt and lines spreading across a map, but here a recognizable settlement takes the place of an abstract financial destination. Lau’s nervous laughter and trembling hand are shown together. Locating a place on a map may be an ordinary informational act; the trembling belongs to the character’s fear. Neither detail amounts to evidence that the worldwide financial network has been dismantled. The scene offers a change in perception, not the accomplished destruction of power.

Unequal Distribution of Narrative Knowledge

The narrator moves in succession through the experiences of Hariharan’s mother, Chandrapal’s son, Raghav’s wife and Lau’s secretary. The people of Garh Narikela have no report of these events: they continue their everyday work. Consequently, the reader knows more than the protagonists of the village’s collective resistance. This asymmetry creates dramatic irony. The community does not celebrate its influence in a continuous triumphal procession, while the reader witnesses the disturbances inside distant households. Such unequal access to knowledge qualifies the novel’s frequent tendency towards immediate declarations of victory. Its dispersed focalisation allows consequences to appear without requiring the characters themselves to know that those consequences exist.

Devika’s Little Printed Lesson

Devika prepares pages for the village school identifying the dangers of fake police threats, the lure of an early online win and the risks of opening an account in another person’s name. The concepts are familiar from preceding chapters; what changes is the medium. Grief is being translated

into reproducible, everyday warnings. Her brother's death remains a source of remembrance, but it also informs attempts to protect living people before an injury occurs. The existence of a printed handout, however, does not establish that everyone read it, understood it or avoided exploitation. The chapter narrates an intervention, not an audited programme of universal protection.

The New Information about Nishant's Resignation

Chapter 43 presents Nishant Jha as having left an impressive position with a foreign company and taken up teaching accounts to village children. This is a substantial development in his professional biography compared with the earlier scenes of financial education. It must be recognized as a narrative statement, while its chronological limits must also be respected: the text does not describe the date, reasons, institutional arrangements or procedure of resignation in detail. A critic should not supply a missing sequence of career events. What the scene does show clearly is the social expression of Nishant's decision, as financial knowledge becomes a practical resource available to children.

Consent Speaks in Meera's Group

During a gathering devoted to privacy, a woman who has been hiding her face in shame herself gives permission for her name to be written. The episode establishes a necessary limitation on the campaign to preserve names. Equal respect for identity does not confer collective ownership of the private information of living persons. This woman determines not only whether her name is spoken, but also to whom, when and how. The campaign's moral principle thus acquires a specific procedure based on consent. Where earlier lists risked treating all names as publicly available material, this small act makes the speaker an author of the conditions under which her own identity enters the record.

Saumya's Multilingual Work of Translation

Saumya carries the English report into Maithili, Hindi, Bengali, Odia, Tamil, Telugu and Urdu, among other languages. In narrative terms, the locally created register of names begins to acquire a subcontinental linguistic reach. But the text does not provide the full translated versions, identify every translator, document reception in each language or demonstrate detailed checks on accuracy. The existence of a language list cannot therefore be treated as proof that the report achieved the same effect among all its intended readers. This episode announces a widening of public access; the degree and quality of that access remain separate questions for criticism.

Ira's Assembly of Names Outside the University

In a distant country, Ira abandons the formal lecture hall and its projector in favour of a gathering where leaves are hung and names are read aloud. Each name is followed by silence. The rhetorical location of resistance shifts from the language of prestigious conferences to an assembled community of listeners. Applause gives way to attention; the paper of institutional scholarship gives way to leaves. Yet a total opposition between university and community would be simplistic: Ira's academic education and her new role as organiser coexist. The scene critiques a particular economy of prestige rather than dismissing the possibility of scholarship serving collective remembrance.

Rumours of Gop's Disappearance

Gop Kumar is less frequently seen. People speculate that he has gone into hiding, died or become stranded while pursuing another source. Whenever a new file is opened, however, his familiar injunction remains: without a name, evidence is incomplete. The narrative leaves his bodily presence uncertain while retaining a distinctive style of writing. Since the narrator presents several rumours rather than confirming one, no critic may turn the conjecture of death into an established event. The device allows absence to acquire dramatic force without resolving the character's actual situation. The survival of a method of inquiry is not identical to proof concerning the investigator's fate.

The Ghosts' Small Tasks in Daylight

The ghosts formerly appeared chiefly in nocturnal games. Now they help hold leaves, draw lines and illuminate the work of living people during the day. Loth's development from fixed spectator towards participant continues gradually. The supernatural community does not principally introduce fresh miraculous events; it supports the labour already undertaken by the living. Burhba acknowledges that children can construct memory while alive. Such mutual recognition changes the distribution of grief. The dead no longer have to carry the responsibility of remembrance alone, and the living no longer occupy the position of frightened onlookers waiting for an apparition to speak.

Assessment of the Section: The Story Enters House after House

The structure of 'The Travelling Burden' begins with the domestic experiences of several antagonistic figures and settles on an expanding catalogue of ordinary tasks undertaken by living people. Aruni attempts once more to write an ending, but sees the word 'work' turning green. This self-referential hesitation before closure is a recurring pulse of the novel. The art is particularly strong in the intimate address 'Batuk', spoken

by Hariharan's mother. Its major textual difficulty is the contradictory information about Raghav's wife. Ignoring that difficulty or inventing a marital reconciliation would both betray source-based criticism. The chapter's significance lies in responsibility entering everyday relationships, not in a completed reconciliation or final judicial result.

Critical Section 145 | Original Chapter 44 — The Granddaughter's Notebook

The fifteenth breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From the Fourteenth Breath's Houses to the Fifteenth Breath's Page

Chapter 43 gave the fourteenth breath the form of a burden travelling from house to house. 'The Granddaughter's Notebook' transforms that experience into a fifteenth breath centred upon the drawings and questions of children. The narrative no longer examines only the bodies and offices of those implicated in exploitation. Fear, like water, finds cracks through which to enter their homes, and the responses of descendants acquire independent importance. The opposing village community is no longer the sole possible agent of change; children within the implicated families begin to speak on their own authority. Their voices represent a possible rupture in inheritance, not the completed punishment or exoneration of their elders.

The Seven-Year-Old Granddaughter's Art

Batuknath's seven-year-old granddaughter draws Channa Grove in her notebook: dark and pale ghosts, demons, Loth and an elderly figure standing outside the playing field. The episode does not fully explain whether she has actually visited the grove or encountered it through dreams and communal stories. On the level of magical realism, the drawing becomes an autonomous passage for distant memory. Wax colours, differently coloured branches and the outline of the excluded old man carry the supernatural stage of earlier chapters onto a domestic table. The scene's force rests on a child's material act of drawing rather than an explicit pronouncement that the picture verifies events she has never witnessed.

A Child Reinterprets the Word 'Victory'

The granddaughter asks why her grandfather is outside the game if he has won. Batuknath tries to separate a legal victory from winning at kabaddi, but the child persistently interrogates their shared word. The social emptiness of his celebrated success becomes intelligible without an elaborate professional argument. This is not a general condemnation of legal practice; the specific object is the ethical meaning of Batuknath's claim. A seven-year-old cannot be presumed to understand the intricacies of court procedure. She nonetheless turns the limits of her knowledge into a question, and that question exposes a contradiction that the adult's specialized language cannot readily settle.

The Notebook as an Alternative Summons

The granddaughter places a little paper in the drawn old man's hand and writes, 'Read the names.' The contrast between an official summons and a child's drawing is compelling. The authoritative commands filling Batuknath's professional room fall silent before two words in a notebook. The drawing is no material writ issued by a court, yet its unanswered demand functions as a moral summons. The author's intended significance is perhaps unusually explicit, but the child's unfamiliar way of approaching institutional language gives the episode life. The scene puts a claim to accountability in a form that neither imitates the court nor depends on the legal standing of the person who utters it.

Injured Young Men Outside Chandrapal's House

A group of young men gathers outside Chandrapal's home and asks permission to tell another child how the initial winnings of an online game concealed a trap. They seek to educate, not to attack the house or enact revenge. Chandrapal's son does not stop them. This moment gives those who experienced exploitation the right to speak in their own voices. In earlier chapters, ghosts and children often spoke for victims; here the injured young men undertake the work of social instruction themselves. The scene therefore extends the question of narrative agency. It offers an alternative to retaliatory spectacle without implying that a single educational visit has ended the underlying network.

Chandrapal's Raised Hand and the Empty Chair

Chandrapal raises his hand as if to strike his son, but a screen-image of Ujjwal's empty chair appears between them. The interruption can be interpreted either as a moment of self-restraint or as restraint imposed by a miracle. More important than the immediate fear on Chandrapal's face is the widening distance between father and son. The son is unwilling to suppress the awakening of those previously exploited. The chair is an apparition of absence, not testimony tested by a court. The scene presents the rupture of familial obedience as an event in its own right; the boundary between the son's moral choice and the image that intervenes remains narratively productive.

Raghav's Daughter and the Family of Questions

Raghav's daughter questions him about the confidential conversations appearing on his phone. Chapter 37 mentioned a son who addressed him as 'Sir' rather than 'Father'; now a daughter is also introduced. There is no necessary contradiction in having both a son and a daughter, although the wider family history has received little prior development. That lack must be distinguished from the more direct temporal problem of the wife said

to have left in one chapter and shown living with him in later scenes. Careful criticism does not merge siblings or invent missing family history. The daughter expands the interrogative space within Raghav's household without settling its chronology.

Lau's Son Asks about Countries and People

Lau's son questions his father's habit of using countries as units in the language of profit while omitting the names of their inhabitants. The father sees a map of aggregate business; the son asks who the people are. A maritime city's apparently borderless commercial imagination becomes a question of social indebtedness in the heir's eyes. The contrast shifts the reader from undifferentiated population categories to individual identification. Yet the chapter does not show the son implementing institutional reforms or initiating legal action. The question is the development reported in the text; outcomes beyond it must not be projected into the story.

Devika's School: The Grammar of Questions

Devika teaches children to respond to phrases such as 'quick money', 'keep it secret' and 'everyone does it' with questions: how, why and whose? Education here replaces the reflex of fear with the courage of scrutiny. The focal centre shifts from the criminal's confidential command to the child's public counter-question. A brief maxim cannot encompass every complication of financial and digital security, and the novel is not supplying an exhaustive operational manual. Its achievement is the framing of a social habit of questioning in a language children can remember. That habit later becomes relevant to the assessment of property, authority and inherited advantage.

Consent Is Questioned inside the Home

Meera explains that permission concerning one's body belongs neither to an owner nor to a crowd, but to the individual. A teenage girl asks what happens when the trade in fear begins inside the family itself. This question challenges the assumption that the home is invariably a refuge for memory and security. Earlier, Munna's household provided a counter-image of shelter; now privacy and safety can become contested within domestic walls. Such complication gives depth to the novel's social world. A collective demand to respect names and persons cannot simply presume that every family will honour a vulnerable member's autonomy.

The Many Responsibilities of 'Whose?'

The children dwell on a single interrogative: whose money, whose death, whose victory, whose order, whose country, whose village and whose

name? Repetition forms a rhythmic pillar through which various claims of institutional ownership are opened to examination. The absence of a ready answer to every question can become a new strength of the novel. If each query were immediately followed by the same magical defeat of an antagonist, the openness of questioning would be diminished. In this chapter, however, the dominant image is that of a door being opened rather than an answer already placed behind it.

Gop's Note on the 'Door'

A brief note in Gop's new file identifies the children of exploiters as the first messengers of questioning. This commentary within the fiction reflects on the novel's own construction. A voice resembling the author's critical perspective appears in an investigative document, bringing diverse incidents together while partly reducing the reader's freedom of interpretation. The principle is no longer simply 'punish', but 'ask'. Its force arises in changed character roles: those expected to inherit silence or unquestioned advantages begin to demand an account of them. The note supplies a formulation of the technique; the household scenes furnish its indispensable experiential substance.

A New Boundary for the Ghosts' Playing Field

Loth asks how the children's teams should now be divided. Ghosts, demons and spirits await a different feeling in the field. The former group of five antagonists is no longer always staged as one compact collection; the narrative has begun to distribute attention among distinct family units. Broome, for example, remains involved through a separate, distant episode centred upon his granddaughter. Absence from a particular scene need not signify disappearance from the wider plot. Such choices are part of multicentred editing, though they make it essential to distinguish the many kinship relations and locations rather than flattening them into one allegorical family.

Conclusion of the Section

The artistic high point of 'The Granddaughter's Notebook' is the seven-year-old's drawing and her deceptively simple question about victory. The chapter introduces an independent voice inside the house of a person implicated in oppression, rather than repeating resistance solely through the voices of his opponents. Gop's note on doors and the recurring question 'whose?' articulate the chapter's larger interrogative design. The repeated immediacy of moral answers emerging on leaves and screens remains a weakness. Nevertheless, there is a distinct event here: descendants begin examining the inheritance their fathers or grandfathers

expect them to accept. The next generation is not yet liberated, but it is no longer merely an echo.

Critical Section 146 | Original Chapter 45 — The Air Within

The sixteenth breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Sixteenth Breath: The Air Beyond the Door

The questions voiced by children in 'The Granddaughter's Notebook' had crossed the threshold of closed rooms. The next chapter names their continuing influence 'The Air Within'. Air joins the smell of fear: bribery, locked doors, managed secrecy and the passive safety of wealth. A child's question becomes more than an isolated exchange; it begins to change a family's atmosphere. Earlier wrongdoing remains subject to legal challenge, but the narrative now places a further question before the heirs who may enjoy its proceeds. The inheritor is not an extension of the accused ancestor. The chapter insists upon an emergent, independent ethical agency within the spaces that material prosperity was meant to secure.

The Granddaughter's Picture Keeps Returning

Batuknath hides his granddaughter's drawing in a drawer, only for it to reappear on his desk, pillow and mirror. The familiar magical mechanism of inscriptions and papers returning after suppression is now applied to a child's work. Its distinctive element is the drawing's provenance: it is not a document prepared by the lawyer's public opponents but the freely produced art of his own granddaughter. The repetition of an established supernatural technique remains conspicuous, and may risk predictability. Yet the living relationship between grandfather and granddaughter intensifies its emotional effect. The drawing does not merely accuse; it exposes the inadequacy of the silence the grandfather has cultivated at home.

The Inheritance of 'Not Telling the Story'

The granddaughter remarks that when a family refuses to tell stories, pictures make themselves. Her observation criticises the mechanisms by which memory is transmitted. If the older generation conceals its history, descendants may find alternative visual ways to represent its absence. Hariharan thinks of leaving his wealth, vehicles, library and name to his family, but begins to recognize that silence, too, can be inherited. Such questioning does not amount to a comprehensive confession of wrongdoing. It is a new beginning for thinking about what a family chooses to preserve. The chapter makes the omission of a story part of the story that will nevertheless reach the young.

The Granddaughter Interrupts Her Grandfather's Touch

Hariharan tries to stroke the child's head, but she draws back and asks for an answer first. Affection and accountability meet in a small bodily gesture. The girl does not abandon her grandfather or renounce love; she refuses to allow tenderness to become a covering for a question that remains unanswered. The episode has greater dramatic precision than a general declaration of anger. The grandfather encounters something resembling testimony, though the child is not a judge imposing legal punishment. The gesture shows how inherited family authority can be questioned without reproducing the violence or humiliation associated with the older generation's practices.

Batra's Son Returns the Car

Chandrapal's son refuses the expensive car. Money, bank papers and business documents are in its boot, and the son asks about the unnamed dead, the indebted families and young victims behind his father's earnings. A car is a tangible form of family wealth; returning it interrupts the automatic acceptance of a privileged inheritance. Nevertheless, handing back the vehicle does not itself discharge contracts, settle accounts or provide compensation. The scene dramatises the beginning of an ethical condition for inheritance rather than a completed financial reckoning. Its character-based importance is that the son's action exists independently of his father's ability to control the narrative of success.

Chandrapal's Wife as a Silent Witness

Chandrapal's wife hears the son refuse the car and shows relief. In this brief appearance the reader perceives traces of an older atmosphere of fear, but she is not given a sustained dialogue of her own. She may recognize in the son's declaration the first clear possibility of truth being spoken inside the household. The limits of her representation remain significant: the narrative has not yet established when she will make an independent decision, or how much she knows about the family's financial conduct. A critic must therefore acknowledge both the meaning of her reaction and the sparseness of her developed agency in this passage.

Raghav's 'Record of Silences'

Raghav's daughter keeps a notebook called 'Record of Silences'. When a message arrives and her father turns his phone over, she writes: 'First silence: the phone turned face down.' The transformation is moving. The man who once engineered invisibility by deleting messages finds his unanswered physical gestures recorded by his child. Silence is now material for domestic history. This does not mean that every quiet moment is automatically evidence of an offence. Its special meaning here arises within

the established context of questions about concealed professional communications. The notebook gives an overlooked daughter the observational role previously monopolised by technological controllers and investigative files.

Lau's Son's Public Essay

Lau's son reads a school essay entitled 'The Inheritance of Profit and the Debt of Names'. On a prize-giving platform, he raises questions about the source of the family's business fortune. Silence replaces the expected applause. The school stage inverses the global platforms from which Broome previously delivered authoritative ethical speeches. An older businessman expounded lofty values, whereas a child asks about the human sources of wealth within his own home. This is a public expression of intention and doubt, not evidence that the son has legally renounced property or successfully changed the corporation. Its narrative significance is the child's appropriation of a platform for independent criticism.

Broome's Granddaughter and the History Book

Edward Broome's granddaughter asks for the names of those who died during the company's earlier projects. His library is filled with substantial volumes of political and ethical thought, yet it appears empty before this particular request. A book's magically blank pages are a folk-fantastic experience rather than a verdict that books or intellectual study are worthless. The failure under scrutiny is the gap between Broome's commanding public vocabulary and his knowledge of the people affected by business decisions. The granddaughter's search turns family history into an expectation of public remembrance. Her question cannot be answered simply by displaying prestigious works already owned by her grandfather.

Descendants Enter a New Team

Ananya asks Ba which team the children of exploiters should join if they arrive with questions. Ba answers that the playing field is not closed to those who come asking. This refuses the idea that a child inherits an immutable moral stain from a parent or grandparent. Investigation of an elder's conduct remains necessary, but hereditary condemnation of the child is rejected. The game's rules acquire a more mature principle of inclusion. Such inclusion must also protect the questioning child's independence and safety; belonging is not a demand to excuse a family's wrongdoing or surrender the claims of victims.

The Inheritance of Fear and the Inheritance of Consent

Meera speaks of silence, shame and fear as things passed through families alongside blood. She proposes another inheritance: the ability to question,

to give or withhold permission, and to control one's own body. This is a metaphor for social reproduction, not a literal biological account of fear. Family habits and concealments can travel across generations, and characters may attempt to interrupt them. Saumya's and Ira's reflections converge here through song, pledge and writing, without becoming identical methods. The right to name abuses and the right not to disclose intimate information must remain complementary within any new tradition of remembrance.

Five Descendants' Questions upon Leaves

In Channa Grove, leaves hold the questions of Hariharan's granddaughter, Batra's son, Raghav's daughter, Lau's son and Broome's granddaughter. The five older figures once appeared as a recognizable network of antagonists; now they are matched by five distinct voices among their descendants. The image does not guarantee one shared future for the children. Their ages, countries, languages and family circumstances differ. The common event is an awakening of questions about inherited authority. The magical leaves arrange these diverse questions in a collective visual pattern while preserving the need to read each child as an independent emerging character.

The Rhythm of 'We Shall Take the Names, Not the Profit'

The children's combined declaration promises to restore names and reject profit obtained by erasing them. After an extended sequence of questions, this is the first large-scale statement of a possible choice by heirs. The ghosts' colours change, and Loth, the demons and Hulasi form a responsive visual assembly. The celebratory image recognizes agency among living descendants. Yet no comprehensive cancellation of inherited property or actual distribution of compensation has occurred. The declaration names an ethical direction; the reader should not convert an emblematic transformation in the spirit-world into proof of a completed restitution scheme.

Critical Assessment of the Sixteenth Breath

The chapter's chief formal contribution is to treat the homes of the accused not merely as repositories of blame, but as new places where change may be contested. A granddaughter's drawing, a son's returned car, a daughter's notebook, a school essay and a history question provide five different material forms of inheritance under examination. These children acquire small rights to choose, rather than remaining undifferentiated symbols of future goodness. A weakness is the remarkably orderly moral vocabulary in which they often speak, leaving little uncertainty typical of

children's speech. Even so, the refusal to classify descendants themselves as criminals is an essential complexity in the novel's social outlook.

Critical Section 147 | Original Chapter 46 — The Darkness of Inheritance

The seventeenth breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From Refusal to Choice

The collective statement 'We shall take the names, not the profit' becomes an examination of actual inherited objects in Chapter 46. The granddaughter's paper, the son's phone, a wife's plate and a grandchild's picture all place the sources of family wealth under scrutiny. The seventeenth breath does not depict property being universally relinquished at once. Its central turn is from unquestioning receipt to the examination of provenance. The old proposal of a register of names now reaches the next generation through inheritance itself. The ethical significance of choosing is broader than simply refusing, although the social and legal results of those choices remain unfinished.

A New Reading of Batuknath's Will

On a blank sheet held by his granddaughter, Batuknath sees three circles: house, account and name. The future heir interrogates the origins of property through drawing, not by issuing a legal pronouncement. The grandfather's orderly will becomes heavy and adhesive in his hand, like a bandage. In this magical sensation, immaculate documentary clauses stand against the human histories excluded from them. It would be mistaken to say that the experience proves the will legally invalid. Rather, the narrative challenges the ethical completeness of a document whose formal arrangement can conceal the social origins of its benefits. The child's drawing makes inheritance a question before it becomes a transaction.

Chandrapal's Son: 'Opportunity' and 'Prey'

Batra's son lays before his father a list containing Ujjwal, Munna and other persons harmed by the network. Chandrapal had taught him to identify 'opportunity'; the son asks what distinguishes an opportunity from prey. The recipient of a business education now independently criticises its premise. Their disagreement is epistemic and generational as much as financial. The son requests an account of the sources of gains standing in his own name. A request for such accounting must not be reported as though a full audit has already been completed. The moment is one in which inheritance becomes conditional upon an answer that the elder has not yet provided.

Raghav's Wife and a Single Grain of Rice

Every day Raghav's wife sets aside one grain from a plate of rice. When he asks why, she connects it to labour made orphaned and the memory of those who have died. A modest domestic practice recalls the human injuries concealed behind a network of secret communications. Even when Raghav leaves the house for a hotel, he sees the solitary grain on every plate. The uncanny repetition expresses an inability to escape the implications of household labour. It does not repair the earlier textual chronology: Chapter 37 said that his wife had left, whereas Chapters 43 and 46 depict her living or eating with him without narrating the intervening change. The contradiction must remain visible.

Lau's Granddaughter's Tree and Phones

Lau's granddaughter draws a tree on a glass surface, with mobile phones hanging like fruit from its branches. Each phone asks about a dead person's name. The tree that carried collective memory in Garh Narikela has acquired a visual afterlife through a child's colours inside a Hong Kong glass office. No literal apparition of Burhba or the village is required for the image to cross a distance. The granddaughter's artistic freedom resembles that of Hariharan's granddaughter in Chapter 44, but the place and the question are distinctive. The scene makes inherited technical wealth answerable to an image of a tree rooted in lives otherwise absent from financial records.

Lau's Property List Demands Translation

Lau considers placing his granddaughter's name among layered holdings distributed across companies, banks, agents, funds and countries. At that moment the list appears to demand the names of the people harmed by the sources of profit. Formal accounting is confronted with an additional question of social provenance. The language of international assets must be translated into the lives of local workers and other victims. The narrative does not offer an exhaustive forensic examination of all those records or a verified ownership diagram. The property list is functioning as a magical instrument of moral questioning, and its ethical insight should not be inflated into a completed financial investigation.

Three Questions: Labour, Harm and Name

Children in the grove are instructed to ask, before accepting an object, whose labour produced it, whose loss attended it and whose name is connected with it. The triad should be compared with earlier principles: 'home, fear, dream' concerned the interior circumstances of persons and families, while 'home, death, humiliation' concerned records of the dead and the social injury done to them. 'Labour, harm, name' investigates

property and its social origin. These may represent different, meaningful purposes, but the narrative does not always specify how each rule is bounded or applied. Criticism must distinguish the work done by successive sets of three rather than declare them interchangeable.

The Toy Car and the Wooden Spinning Top

A child receives a shining toy car but cannot say whose labour made it; it is therefore kept out of the game. Another recognizes the wooden spinning top made by his grandfather, and the toy is included. The paired objects offer a condensed critique of consumption: familiar workmanship is valued over mere brilliance. The example should not, however, be extended into a universal rule that an industrial product is morally unacceptable whenever a child cannot name its maker. Such a rigid extrapolation would overburden the symbolic game. What the episode teaches is the practice of asking about the histories of objects, not an automatic disqualification of all unfamiliar manufactured goods.

The Limit of 'Inheritance' in Meera's Private Life

Meera insists that another person's love, body or fear cannot be treated as inheritable property. This is a crucial limit on the collective investigation of wealth: a movement concerned with social provenance must not claim ownership over intimate personal autonomy. Enthusiasm for asking about descendants and inheritance must not become compulsory disclosure. Devika adds the problem of ignorance in mule accounts; Nishant contributes financial distinctions; Saumya considers language. The discussion thus extends from property to the complex boundary between publicly accountable resources and a person's own protected relationships. Social remembrance has ethical force only when it respects the permission of those whose lives enter the record.

Burhba's Daylight Transformation

For the first time Burhba appears fully embodied in daylight; the black body bears the grey of ash. The transformation is not a declaration of the ghost's final release, but a change in how the supernatural community is seen as the living acquire greater ethical maturity. Channa Grove's status as a fearful nocturnal stage is loosened. The diminishing illumination around the demon extends the suggestion that the questions of children are becoming an independent source of light. These are ritual and magical images that clarify a narrative meaning. They are not statistical reports of completed social reform.

Crossing out 'Refusal' and Writing 'Choice'

Ananya initially calls the seventeenth breath 'The Heir's Refusal', then crosses out the last word and substitutes 'Choice'. This minor act of editing is formally decisive. The negative gesture of renunciation becomes a positive right to select the history, names, labour and love one is willing to carry forward. The children are no longer concerned only with not accepting tainted money; they ask what sort of collective future they themselves may author. Aruni sees that the writer is no longer the sole authority over words. The narrative's own editing becomes a visible event, making a child's revision more precise than another supernatural proclamation of reform.

Paper Sinks into the Earth and Sprouts

Instead of being carried away by the wind, the collective page enters the soil and becomes a coconut shoot. Written choice takes the form of a possible biological future: paper becomes a seed. The image returns explicitly to Chapter 39's 'Peace of the Seed'. The impossible botanical birth is a legitimate element of magical realism, not verifiable evidence of durable institutional transformation. Its value lies in joining the work of inscription to the expectation of future growth. The chapter's symbolism is strongest when the shoot remains an emblem of work to be done rather than a guarantee that the harvest has already arrived.

The Different Defences of the Rogues

Batuknath hesitates before signing; Chandrapal attempts to remove his son's name; Raghav changes hotels yet cannot evade the single grain of rice; Lau orders the removal of his granddaughter's drawing. These are distinct responses to the same broad challenge. The children's questions do not make all fathers and grandfathers penitents. Some respond with anger, some with attempts to preserve assets, others with flight or concealment. The diversity of these defensive behaviours matters more than a uniformly consoling moral pattern. It keeps character psychology partially open and makes inherited advantage a contested relation rather than an automatically resolved dilemma.

Judgment on the Section

The major contribution of 'The Darkness of Inheritance' is the substitution of 'choice' for 'refusal' as a principle of narration. The granddaughter's picture, the grandson's or son's inquiries, the source-list, Meera's limit on public claims and the grandfather-made top transform objects into mirrors of labour history. Change does not arrive fully formed after a declaration; the antagonists' resistance remains. Ananya's act of editing is in fact a subtler literary innovation than another self-writing

magical page. Nor do the earlier contradictions in the domestic histories of characters disappear. The episode leaves the ethical implications of inheritance active while declining to pretend that legal or familial disputes have been settled.

Critical Section 148 | Original Chapter 47 — The Elephant and the Crocodile: A Narrative

The eighteenth breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Eighteenth Breath's New Mythic Stage

'The Elephant and the Crocodile' recasts the preceding debate about inheritance within an older narrative of river, water and capture. Ba begins with a brass bowl and soil from the Kamla–Balan bank, telling of the elephant whose foot is caught by a crocodile. The inherited religious narrative is not simply laid over the novel unchanged. Questions arising in Garh Narikela—who is the elephant, who is the crocodile, and what is the water?—redefine its contemporary application. The myth becomes a narrative embedded within the novel, a distinct level of telling rather than another event in the primary chronological sequence. This difference between story levels is fundamental to interpreting the chapter.

The Question of a Third Hand, Said to Be the Rescuer

Ba's version does not stop at the elephant's strength and the crocodile's violence. She asks what an outside helper or third hand might do. Three relational positions become important: the exploited person, the exploiter and the observer or institution capable of responding. The opposition between prolonged court delays and the community's reading of names acquires a fresh stage through the myth. Yet no historical character is assigned an immutable identity as elephant, crocodile or rescuer. Roles can change within the game. The narrative invites an examination of positions of power and responsibility rather than distributing permanent moral animal identities among the cast.

Ananya's Map of Water Filled with Names

Ananya puts words into the water between the elephant and crocodile: Ujjwal, Sarayu, Nand, thirty, three hundred, mule accounts, privacy and breath. Diverse crises from earlier chapters are compressed into a single folk-narrative field. Such compression has poetic force, but it does not make all the terms equivalent. 'Thirty' refers to an official list, while 'three hundred' functions as the larger claim of community memory and investigation. The latter should not be treated as a verified final total merely because the words appear together in one image. The critic must preserve differences between a proper name, an institutional category, a numerical allegation and a thematic symbol even inside the myth's common water.

Mei-Lata in Lau's Family: A Name of Mixed Origins

Mei-Lata, a girl raised within Lau's family, joins the game of Garh Narikela. An Indian nanny had called her 'Lata' in childhood, producing the mixed history of her name. Chapter 45 referred to Lau's son and Chapter 46 to a granddaughter; the text provides no basis for identifying Mei-Lata with either. She should be read as a separately introduced girl connected with that family. Her appearance establishes a new multilingual and transnational focal point. What connects her to Mithila is not an invented genealogy but a remembered form of address crossing language and geography. The small history of a name carries more specificity than any claim that all descendants share the same identity.

Hariharan's Granddaughter Plays the Crocodile

In the first round Ananya plays the elephant and Hariharan's granddaughter the crocodile. The act of gripping a foot is a chosen role in a game, not an attribution of inherited wickedness. As Ananya says the names Sarayu, Ujjwal and Nand, the grip loosens. Within the allegory, remembrance becomes a magical condition of release. But the child's family connection does not turn her into the moral equivalent of the older exploiter. Indeed, the power of this sequence rests on the ability to enter and leave roles voluntarily. To assign criminality by birth would contradict the inclusive principle developed in the preceding chapters.

Questioning the Traditional Fixity of Elephant and Crocodile

The elephant is physically strong; the crocodile enjoys an advantage while gripping its prey beneath the water. Yet the novel has previously made water the medium through which the names of the dead are carried as well as the place where workers disappeared. Water cannot therefore be classified simply as an accomplice of violence. This double symbolism is indispensable. The river has borne bodies away, but the same river transmits tales and memories of those bodies. Reading its natural setting as a one-dimensional villain would erase the novel's developed hydrological imagination. The mythic roles gain meaning from their interaction with that earlier ambiguity.

Satyavrat Chooses to Listen rather than Read

In the distant city, Satyavrat Mehta opens a book containing the older elephant-and-crocodile story, but the narrator suggests that the story is now reading him. This self-reflexive reversal displaces the official reader from his accustomed place of authority. Satyavrat begins to understand himself not as a rescuing deity but as an accountable member of an institution that has failed to hear others. The papers he considers carrying would also bring his own institution into question. This is a prospective

institutional encounter, not yet an actual arrival, confession or order. Its immediate narrative reality is the change in the reader's conception of his responsibility.

Devika's Indispensable Question of the Name

In the course of the elephant-and-crocodile game a participant falters while giving a name. Devika asks that the person first say their own name. The earlier rule of respect for names becomes an immediate action again. Accountability in a crisis may begin with the ability to identify oneself, but naming alone cannot provide compensation, guarantee safety or establish culpability. Devika's presence is distinctive because her public teaching has grown out of the painful experience of Ujjwal's death. The words therefore need to be understood as an acquired, difficult practice rather than a lifeless repetition of the supernatural assembly's commands.

The Crocodile Imprisoned by Hunger

For the first time Panidubbi says that the crocodile, too, may be captive to hunger, though making hunger into a religion is a crime. This statement introduces a subtlety into the discussion of exploitation. Material deprivation and the personal decision to prey upon others are connected without being made identical. Explaining the place of hunger in a life does not justify deliberate harm. The distinction between poverty and organized profit must be maintained. If the crocodile were reduced to pure demonic appetite and the elephant to unquestionable innocence, the earlier complexity of the novel's characters would be lost. The sentence enlarges the moral debate without cancelling responsibility.

Raghav's Nephew and the Relations of Heirs

The game introduces a nephew of Raghav 'Signal'. Chapter 45 mentioned a daughter and Chapter 37 a son. These are not necessarily inconsistent: a nephew, daughter and son may all belong to the same extended family. The text has, however, left much of the wider family structure and the chronology of cohabitation unexplained. It would be wrong to substitute the nephew for one of the children or merge them into one person merely to simplify the narrative. The expanding kinship circle offers another possible pathway for questions of inheritance while making close attention to relationship terms essential.

Changing Dates upon the Ticket

After returning from Garh Narikela, Batuknath sees the date on a train ticket change every day. In this supernatural disturbance of time, the journey becomes not a single completed historical event but a continuing experience of inner accountability. Chapters 23, 26, 35 and 40 have already

offered repeated journeys or arrivals at the village without sufficient chronological markers to establish their order unambiguously. The mutable ticket strengthens their artistic interpretation as recurring ethical travel, but does not itself verify the sequence of external events. A critic must distinguish temporal symbolism from the still unresolved chronology of the character's movements.

The Capacity to Hear: Court, Listening and Repentance

Ba imagines Satyavrat coming not with a sword or a triumphant judicial order but with ears. The institutional failure repeatedly depicted in the novel begins with an inability to listen to the names and experiences of the injured. Creating conditions for dialogue is not a total rejection of punishment; meaningful hearing is an ethical prerequisite for just proceedings. The community's record must still reach the court, where factual verification and lawful redress remain separate questions. At this stage the novel dwells upon training the capacity to hear, not upon a conclusive account of punishment or pardon. The distinction protects the scene from an unduly easy theology of redemption.

The Unfinished Eighteenth Breath

Water continues to circle within the elephant-and-crocodile game. The exhausted elephant's breath remains suspended while the next cry is awaited. This ending echoes the halted kabaddi of Chapter 39 and the germination of Chapter 46. Instead of a conclusion, the novel gives another suspended call. The device is part of its extensive narrative architecture, but there is a formal risk: when chapter after chapter claims that everything is still beginning, the dramatic power of endings may weaken. Here the questioning of an inherited myth provides a substantive new reason for suspension. The expected release is no longer merely miraculous; its meaning depends on a community's capacity to respond.

Narratological Judgment on the Elephant and Crocodile

The chapter's chief achievement is its renewed connection of an old mythic form with Garh Narikela's water geography, bridge labour, financial exploitation, privacy and disputes over inheritance. Mei-Lata's mixed name, Satyavrat's self-questioning, Panidubbi's observation about the crocodile's hunger and the children's exchangeable roles add different layers of significance. A limitation is the occasional explicitness with which the earlier crocodile motif is joined to the crocodile of the myth. The distinct historical causes of suffering must remain legible beneath the shared image. In the end, the episode waits not for a hero's magical deliverance but for the collective possibility of hearing the next call.

Inter-Sectional Assessment: The Narratological Conjunction of Chapters 40–47

Across these eight chapters the structure expands progressively from 'Letters of Dew' to the elephant-and-crocodile narrative. The eleventh breath joins a name to an object from a life; the twelfth turns objects into routes of experience; the thirteenth asks who must carry the weight of those routes; the fourteenth sends that weight into households. The fifteenth gives a granddaughter's drawing and children's questions a place in the story. The sixteenth makes heirs question inherited property; the seventeenth transforms 'refusal' into 'choice'; the eighteenth introduces the old tale of elephant and crocodile as another interpretive stage. Game, object, register, domestic speech and myth thus retain distinct genres while forming a continuous line of development.

Two groups of textual difficulties remain especially serious. The identification of Sarayu Devi or Sarayu Mahato has not been reconciled: an earlier woman worker stands beside Kamli's later reference to 'Father' and a wife's garment. Raghav's wife was said to have left in Chapter 37, yet appears serving food in Chapters 43 and 46 without an intervening account. These are problems in character biography, not simply supernatural symbols. The earlier inconsistent representations of Ujjwal's death and the chronology of Batuknath's journeys remain open as well. Raghav's son, daughter and nephew, together with Lau's son, granddaughter and Mei-Lata, must not be collapsed into one person without textual evidence.

The most affecting moments move beyond self-writing leaves and endlessly responsive screens into material actions: Kamli's broken anklet, an old woman's partial recollection of 'a Monday in Bhadon', a bank clerk's initial marking of fourteen accounts, Meera's insistence on consensual recording, an injured woman preparing to go to the police, Raghav's daughter keeping a record of silences, Batra's son returning a car, Ananya replacing 'refusal' with 'choice', and Satyavrat's preparation to listen. Each small action has a concrete object, a limited duration and an incomplete result; that incompleteness gives the episode social credibility.

The mythic inset of Chapter 47 gives the magical-realist novel another depth. Rather than taking elephant and crocodile as fixed moral assignments, it reads them through labour, resources, power and the listener's responsibility. This remains a possible narrative interpretation, not verification of every extraordinary coincidence as a documented social cause. The analysis therefore rests upon narrative time, focalisation, self-reference, linguistic repetition, the handling of archival objects and contradictions in character continuity—not upon a Navya-Nyaya examination of proof.

Critical Section 149 | Original Chapter 48 — The Call

The nineteenth breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From the Eighteenth Breath's Waiting to the Nineteenth Breath's Listening

The elephant-and-crocodile game of Chapter 47 stopped while the exhausted elephant awaited a cry. Chapter 48 converts that suspension into the discipline of a new breath. Earlier, the fundamental rule was to pronounce the correct name; now a new question emerges: who can become capable of hearing it? The organisation of events shifts from speech to the responsibility of reception. A folk song first asks that the whole story be heard, and the following scenes test the request through an empty bowl, silence and the delayed arrival of a listener. The song's ethical proposal must be distinguished from what is actually performed in the ensuing narrative.

Dew That Will Not Dry and Time That Will Not Pass

The dew on the leaves of Channa Grove persists well after dawn, even when the day grows warm. Women complete their domestic work, children set out with their bags and elders sit in the courtyard. Ordinary activity continues around a small supernatural suspension. The dew marks the long duration of an unanswered call without bringing all clock time to a halt. This contrast allows the reader to experience communal remembrance as a temporality different from the measured hours of domestic routine. The story's magical realism does not abolish everyday life; it inserts an unresolved waiting into its smallest visible detail.

The Empty Bowl as a New Image of Listening

Ananya brings an empty bowl instead of another empty sheet. A vessel already filled with its own image might trap the speaker's voice; an empty vessel leaves room for another person's account. The change is narratologically important. Leaves, paper, screens and stones had served mainly as surfaces for writing; the bowl must first receive. Burhba places an ear against it, making even the supernatural authority learn how to listen. The bowl is no technical substitute for a legal record. Its force lies in the construction of an open relationship between speaker and listener, not in the miraculous completeness of what can be heard.

The Trembling Letters of Sarayu and the Question of Identity

Children begin to write Sarayu's name. Some form the first consonant imperfectly; others misplace a vowel mark. Ba recognizes the human uncertainty of learning rather than immediately punishing an error. The scene distinguishes the need for an accurate name from the vulnerability of a child's first attempt to write it. At the same time, the earlier conflict between Sarayu Devi and Sarayu Mahato, and between female worker and father, remains unresolved. The trembling letters cannot repair this discrepancy in identity. The emotional meaning of a learning scene and the stable identification required by a continuing register are separate critical matters.

Devika's Call: From Grief to School

Devika places Ujjwal's phone on the soil and asks that his name be written in the school rather than simply enacted in the ghostly game. The decision moves private mourning into the practical structure of education. A living sister's action becomes more important than an abstract heroic cry within a magical competition. Devika has not ceased to grieve; she chooses work because of grief. The phone, once the medium of intimidation, now raises questions of testimony and prevention. Its possible educational use nevertheless requires attention to the earlier privacy strand: vulnerable digital material cannot simply be circulated without regard to consent and protection.

Restoring the Shadow of the Living Munna

Munna Paswan is called among the dead although he is alive. His bank account, the threat of criminal classification and the fragmentation of his social identity express a different kind of dispossession from death. Ananya asks him to speak from within the circle, while Burhba raises the shadow left behind and places it by his feet. This magical restoration depicts the damage of having a name detached from one's person. Ba distinguishes knowingly planned wrongdoing from an act undertaken in ignorance. Munna's account of what he knew is not, however, an automatic legal acquittal. Communal recognition and forensic examination remain independent narrative levels.

Satyavrat's Bell and the Bridge of Sound between City and Village

In a government library in Delhi, Satyavrat's brass bell, ordinarily used to summon an attendant, rings by itself. Another sound resembles the resonance of the empty bowl, and the scent of the Kamla–Balan bank enters the air. The novelist connects the official's inner life to the village call without requiring a messenger or telephone. The bell, once an instrument of commanding another person, is transformed into a sign of

the need to hear. Its uncanny ringing is an event within the novel's mode of perception, not a realistic report of telecommunications between office and village. Its narrative purpose is the reversal of the direction in which authority expects communication to travel.

Reading Files and Hearing Names: A Displacement of Knowledge

Satyavrat re-examines his long habit of reading files. Printed names become categories, cases, provisions and dates; in a child's call, those same names return as homes, bodies, hunger, humiliation and waiting. The novel does not declare administrative writing worthless. Rather, it criticises the dehumanising uses of records when their distinction from oral memory becomes absolute. Satyavrat's recognition of this gap is an internal event of character. It should not immediately be announced as a successful reform of official procedures. The change in a person's awareness and the change in the system's conduct belong to different temporal and institutional registers.

A Journey in an Ordinary Compartment: Training to Listen

Satyavrat declines the government vehicle, security escort and reserved railway comfort, choosing to travel in a regular compartment. Around him a young man watches a game, a woman feeds a child and a worker rests upon a bundle. This scene moves beyond supernatural contact to the directly experienced bodies and daily time of ordinary travellers. Official distance begins to lessen. But a humble journey does not by itself constitute a government decision or redress the official's previous silence. The narrative gives Satyavrat the first journey of an apprentice listener, not a ceremonial procession of a state-appointed saviour.

Honours Suspended upon Arrival at the Grove

When Satyavrat arrives at Channa Grove, there is no applause, ceremonial bow or platform. The empty bowl stands in the middle, children sit in a circle and the ghosts remain behind them. The arrival of a representative of the state does not give him immediate command of the narrative. The community accepts him on the condition that he listen. A site that had previously served as a dramatic counterpart to the formal court now regulates the visitor's turn to speak. His statement 'I shall listen' matters, but it remains a promise of attention rather than the completed result of evidence collection or judicial action.

Meera's Quiet Call for Privacy

Meera says that her love is not a crime; blackmail through stolen personal material is. The narrator describes the call of privacy as the quietest of all. The new public practice of listening must therefore be tested against the

individual's right to determine the time, scope and conditions of disclosure. A community may have a duty to hear, but not a limitless claim to another person's intimate history. If the name archive automatically exposed private details, it would contradict its own pledge of dignity. Meera's quiet voice is the internal critical limit upon a culture of public remembrance, not a lesser or incomplete form of testimony.

The Lie of Compensation and the Unfinished Full Name

The requirements for a complete name now include the home, labour, a child's waiting and the falsehoods surrounding compensation. The list is no longer merely a ceremonial roll of the dead; it is a programme of social and historical inquiry. In this movement the earlier sequence of name, object, route and burden is connected. Yet the phrase 'the lie of compensation' is a broad moral characterization. It does not provide the amount, documents or circumstances of every particular payment to every family. Criticism may not insert invented figures to conceal the gaps of the source. The register's incompleteness must remain an acknowledged part of its form.

Postponing Apology and Recording the Name of Silence

Satyavrat observes that asking forgiveness might itself become a convenient way to lighten his conscience. He therefore asks that the days of his silence be written into the record. This act of self-limitation marks a stronger stage of personal accountability. The novelist displaces the role of a great judicial hero who arrives to rescue everyone: this listener sits among those whose histories his office failed to hear. Even so, a morally significant confession is not equivalent to the successful execution of institutional reform. The community does not break into praise; it proceeds with the reading of names. This refusal of instant absolution gives the scene its discipline.

The Unfinished Conclusion of the Nineteenth Breath

Kabaddi begins again under a revised rule: whoever takes a breath will say a name; whoever says a name will listen; whoever listens will not flee. Satyavrat remains seated outside the circle. His task is not to win the game but to endure the duty of listening. Dew upon the leaves forms the word 'Call' in the notebook, while Ananya asks not for a deity but for ears able to hear their own silence. The new rule joins the recitation of names to psychological responsibility. The nineteenth breath does not finish: practice continues. The narrative achieves an expanded ethical duration for hearing, not a miraculous or comprehensive liberation.

Critical Section 150 | Original Chapter 49 — The Record of Silence

The twentieth breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Debt of Having Heard the Call

In Chapter 48 Satyavrat sat in Channa Grove and heard the call; in the twentieth breath the reckoning begins for the debt incurred by listening. This is the necessary next stage in the novel's ethics of attention. Hearing is not merely a passive act of sympathy: it entails retaining people's names, acknowledging the incompleteness of family histories and sources, and giving practical effect to what has been heard. The folk song describes a statement once heard as a debt. The prose then tests that proposition through a bowl that grows heavy though empty, a notebook filling with entries, and the difficulty of reading what has been written. These images do not furnish a completed account of social action. They dramatise the interval between receptivity and responsibility.

An Empty Bowl Grows Heavy, and So Do the Ears

The nineteenth breath insisted that the bowl remain empty. In the twentieth, that emptiness acquires an opposite significance: without water, the vessel becomes heavy with the names it has received. Satyavrat attempts to lift it and initially fails. The narrative imagines an impossible physical weight for the moral substance of testimony. This miracle makes the character's inward state visible; it offers no numerical measurement of an actual hearing. How many names, families and instances of silence have been recorded remains a separate empirical question. The narrator's change of material scale—from a nearly weightless empty vessel to an object that resists the hand—turns attentive listening into an experience the body cannot set aside at will.

'The Names of Silence Remain': Expanding the Register

Burhba prevents Satyavrat from closing his notebook: the people's names have been written, but the names of silence remain. The scope of the record widens beyond those who died to include those who omitted an entry, intimidated someone into silence, failed to object or saw an event without speaking. Yet the novel does not make all silence equivalent. A victim silenced by fear, a subordinate obeying orders and a controller protecting profit occupy different positions within unequal structures of power. Ba explicitly draws attention to this distinction. The widening register is narratively important precisely because the critic must resist

turning it into an indiscriminate roll of culpability. Silence may require explanation before it can bear a specific judgment.

Sarayu's Entry and the Refusal of an Invented Solution

The first silence is entered beside Sarayu's name: that of the official who failed to ask the name of a woman labourer. This passage plainly identifies Sarayu as female. Chapters 40–41, however, presented Sarayu Mahato as Kamli's 'Babuji', a male father with a wife. The contradiction has now become more concrete. Two persons sharing a name, a change in family identification or an inconsistency in narration are all conceivable, but the source supplies no conclusive reconciliation. Faithful criticism cannot construct one apparently seamless biography by selecting the version it prefers. The ethical force of the missing entry should be examined alongside—not at the expense of—the source's unresolved problem of personal identity.

Devika's 'Sister's Silence': Unequal Weights of Self-Reproach

Recalling that she failed to recognise Ujjwal's fear in time, Devika asks for her silence as a sister to be written down. This is a delicate development in her character. Self-scrutiny accompanies bereavement, but it must not confuse the responsibility of people who designed digital threats and extracted money with that of a family member who could not understand a concealed ordeal. Ba states the necessary difference: guilt and silence are not the same thing. The distinction prevents Devika's own self-accusation from becoming the critic's exclusive explanation of Ujjwal's death. Her entry is evidence of mourning and moral reflection, not a judicial allocation of causal blame. The story makes room for conscience without transferring the perpetrators' responsibility onto the bereaved.

Munna's Account and the Question of the Bank

Munna recalls that on the day his account was opened a bank employee examined his identity papers several times and then spoke to someone on the telephone. He now asks whom that conversation might have informed. The bank's silence enters the register, but a distinction must be maintained between the original observed action and Munna's subsequent interpretation. What the employee actually knew has not been established. The story raises the ethical question of failing to speak after noticing something suspicious, while refraining from a final verdict of criminal guilt against a named employee. This incompleteness is integral to the depiction of financial asymmetry: the vulnerable account-holder has reason to suspect a system whose internal communications remain inaccessible to him.

Hariharan's Granddaughter Asks a Question in Return

Batuknath is awake in the village rest house; the copy of the order seems ragged at its edges. His granddaughter asks whether Grandfather will enter his own name in the register of silence. The child's earlier notebook now acquires a new classificatory purpose. He attempts to evade her by saying that he is a man of law; she places the relationship between procedure and silence before him. The scene does not present a completed admission of wrongdoing. Batuknath continues to resist identifying himself in that manner. The paper's magical damage is an emblem of psychological unease, not an actual revision of a court record. Through the child's ordinary demand for consistency, a private household becomes a place where legal self-description is tested.

Batra's Screen and Raghav's Silence of Command

Chandrapal takes his damaged screen for replacement, and the shopkeeper remarks that the trouble lies with the picture inside it. A message intended to order Raghav to stop the game of names becomes 'Silence sent'. In Raghav's room, deleted messages descend as leaves, disclosing the boundaries between issuing instructions and remaining silent at decisive moments. The parallel montage links command and omission within the same network of exploitation. Its limitation lies in the repetition of an established magical technique: screens and messages repeatedly rewrite themselves to convey the same moral pressure. A critic must therefore ask what fresh relation this episode reveals, rather than treating each returning inscription as evidence of a new, independently verified exposure.

The Different Experiences of a Banker, Compounder and Clerk

A bank employee, a compounder who worked during the pandemic and a lawyer's clerk responsible for recording hearing dates attend the gathering. The banker recognises the omission involved in leaving the 'other observations' space blank; the compounder recalls hiding behind 'orders from above'; the clerk confronts the neglect of a waiting mother. These figures stand outside the established group of five principal antagonists. Their appearance gives the narrative a more complex account of the lesser intermediaries through whom institutional harm can persist. Their access to information, degrees of control and material benefits cannot be assumed to be equal. The register is at its strongest when it makes such distinctions audible rather than reducing everyone to the same collective verdict.

The Different Social Risks of Writing and Reading

Writing silence in a notebook allows the writer to look down at paper; reading it aloud may require looking towards the person concerned. The empty bowl announces the next task: public reading. The trembling bodies of the employee and clerk render this change in medium perceptible. Documentation is no longer a private refuge for self-confession but the beginning of a dialogue about accountability. Nonetheless, public acknowledgment must not become coercive merely because the community regards it as virtuous. Fear of legal consequences and unequal social standing may make compulsory disclosure itself harmful. The chapter's ethical method thus needs both the courage of open speech and careful limits on the demand that another person speak.

Ira and the Silence of the Foreign Auditorium

Ira records an occasion on which no one raised a question at an overseas ethics conference. Meanwhile, the words 'Record of Silence' appear in a draft of Edward Broome's next address. Polite academic quiet and the elaborate rhetoric of business ethics enter the same critical structure. Ira's inclusion of her own omissions is especially important: the group opposing exploitation does not exempt itself from examining moments when it failed to intervene. Yet the exact chronology of conference appearances and silences is not fully settled in this passage. The reader should distinguish the character's retrospective understanding from an independently reconstructed sequence of events. Self-examination deepens the narrative without licensing invented precision.

Fourteen Lanterns and Loth's Light

Fourteen lanterns burn at night. Loth places a hand beside one of them, but the light does not diminish. The scene revises the older conception of ghosts as beings belonging necessarily to darkness. The villagers bring their own lamps; supernatural bodies are no longer the sole bearers of illumination. Loth's prolonged position as spectator continues to yield to modest cooperation. The number fourteen organises a collective visual scene; it is not a basis for concluding that there are exactly fourteen verified names, households or bank accounts. The narrative's arithmetic here is part of a symbolic arrangement, and should not be confused with a completed count in any of its documentary inquiries.

The Bowl Becomes Light; the Hands Become Heavy

After the names and silences are read, the apparently empty bowl can finally be lifted. Ba observes that the bowl is light and the hands are heavy: it is through such hands that work gets done. The concluding reversal answers the chapter's opening miracle. Responsibility has moved out of the

magical object and into the bodies of those expected to act. Satyavrat speaks of taking responsibility for safeguarding what has been heard, but no finished institutional mechanism or complete evidentiary record is shown. The weight is now a demand on action, not proof of restitution. The ending refuses the easy relief of a confession that cleanses the person speaking while leaving the underlying obligations untouched.

The Twentieth Breath: Readers of the Register

'The Record of Silence' converts the art of preserving names into a layered examination of administrative delay, domestic reticence, commercial benefit and bystanders who decline to listen. Ba's distinction between guilt and silence guards against the danger of entering radically unequal experiences under a single accusatory heading. The narrative critiques not merely its established antagonists but also the omissions of those engaged in resistance. The twentieth breath does not deliver a final verdict. It anticipates a further stage in which names written down must travel and be tested in different places. The future promised by the text must not be reported as an achieved result. What this chapter establishes is the reader's duty to distinguish record, acknowledgment and practical response.

Critical Section 151 | Original Chapter 50 — The Name after the Body

The twenty-first breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From the Twentieth Breath's Register to the Twenty-first Breath's Body

'The Record of Silence' placed silences beside names. Chapter 50 gives those written names a new visual existence in the earth of Channa Grove and the body of a pond. 'The Name after the Body' does not announce the literal immortality of a person after death. Its proposition is that the social meaning of a life extinguished by violence need not disappear with the body. The folk song invokes roots, trees, inscriptions and shadows, while the prose proceeds through the sudden appearance of a pond, floating letters, the elephant-and-crocodile parable and Satyavrat's bodily experience. A song's anticipation of future work must not be mistaken for an event already achieved in the ensuing prose.

Satyavrat Standing Outside the Grove

Satyavrat stands outside Channa Grove without anyone stopping him or instructing him to enter. His hesitation at the threshold externalises an unresolved inner state. Chapter 48 had brought him to the grove and made him promise to listen; Chapter 49 had him spend the night recording silences. Chapter 50 again begins with him outside. This might mark a return on another night, a renewed inward crossing of the threshold or a discontinuity of chronology. The text does not furnish a clear temporal bridge. The critic must preserve the possibilities rather than fabricate a definite day of departure and re-entry. The scene's human significance lies in hesitation, not in a chronology the original has not supplied.

The Body Remembers: Provisions and Heartbeats

The narrator evokes the layers of provisions, subsections, rulings and interpretations in the mind of a seasoned legal practitioner. Against this familiar professional structure come the soles of Satyavrat's feet, his heartbeat and the sensation of breathing. The contrast criticises this particular character's habitual distance from the bodily costs of ordinary people's work and suffering. It is not an outright rejection of legal knowledge. Rather, the novel asks how intellectual competence may coexist with a failure of attention. Satyavrat's temporary silence is preparation for learning, not itself an act of reform. The bodily register

introduces an experience that cannot be exhausted by the categories of professional analysis.

The Time of a Pond Appearing Overnight

An entirely new pond appears in the middle of the grove, although no one has dug it. Letters, rather than the moon, float upon its surface. This supernatural emergence makes river, pond and grove different shapes of the same social memory. Letters that scatter and reassemble present the recovery of names after bodies have been destroyed. The event must not be reported as a literal excavation, an act of water management or an independently verified geographical alteration. The novel's magical landscape gives visual form to the practices of its imagined court of memory. The pond expands the possibilities of narration, not the catalogue of measurable engineering works.

Names Written on Water and the Incomplete List

Satyavrat sees such names as Sarayu Devi, Budhan Miyan, Jagesar Paswan and Ujjwal Jha in the water. The narrative says explicitly that these names did not appear in his government case-law volumes or appendices. The encounter makes the lives excluded from official knowledge visible again. Yet subsequent unnamed people do not receive fully developed personal histories in the source; criticism cannot invent them. Sarayu's identity as a woman returns here, leaving unresolved her relation to the male Sarayu Mahato described as Kamli's father in Chapters 40–41. The uncertainty is part of the text's documentary problem, whereas the watery naming is part of its imaginative achievement.

Writing 'Silence' beside One's Own Name

Ananya asks Satyavrat whether his own name will also be written. He utters 'silence' beside that name, and the water turns once. An official with authority now marks the absence of his past intervention alongside the remembrance of victims. The single entry does not establish the full professional liability of all his previous decisions. His own acknowledgment should be interpreted within the limits the narrative gives it. There is a precise progression: first he hears, and then he acknowledges silence. The pond's response magnifies the moment without expanding it into a court's findings. Self-recognition becomes an event in characterisation, not an instant replacement for a public inquiry.

Memory's Grip in the Retelling of the Elephant and Crocodile

A long shadow assumes the form of an elephant or a person, and a crocodile rises from the pond. The grip on the elephant's leg in the older story becomes the grip of memory. The elephant struggles, the hold

deepens, and the bonds loosen gradually as names are called. The myth nested in earlier narration is now enacted within the events of the fictional world. But the original leaves open whether the elephant is ultimately freed or dies. To impose an unequivocal happy ending would erase a deliberate, or at least present, ambiguity. The episode's meaning depends on this resistance to a totalising account of deliverance: the call of names may loosen captivity without proving that harm has been undone.

Batuknath's Shadow Objects to Jurisdiction

Batuknath's body remains in the village rest house while his shadow enters the grove, carrying an order and demanding to know which court has jurisdiction. Burhba answers in terms of the people's authority over memory. This split presence distinguishes the character's body, psychological apprehension and public standing. The narrative does not show Batuknath submitting a fresh formal objection before a recognised court. It is his shadow that speaks during a supernatural confrontation. Jurisdiction in law and the community's claim to remembrance are being compared metaphorically. Treating them as an ordinary procedural hearing would confuse two deliberately separate narrative planes and credit the fiction with a legal event it does not depict.

Batra's Screen, Raghav's Message and Lau's Sea

The scene cuts between Chandrapal's consciousness reaching the grove as a screen, Raghav's deleted messages becoming leaves and waves near Lau uttering Maithili names. Established magical devices are brought together in a compact geography. Each antagonist's fear returns through the medium associated with his activities; extensive networks can be condensed into a single stretch of narrated time. This compression deepens the water motif, but also risks monotony. If every object belonging to the antagonists becomes the same kind of supernatural notice of guilt, eventfulness declines even as imagery accumulates. The critic should register both the structural coherence and the limits of repetition.

Gop's Unwritten Leaf

Gop Kumar sits without paper, holding a dry coconut leaf. Devika asks what is now to be written. For a character previously identified with columns, lists and copies, the pause is notable. The blank leaf does not imply that the work of preserving names has ended. It points instead towards an unidentified purpose beyond recording letters. The local investigator and keeper of documents waits for the physical and social work that must follow the act of listening. This suspension is a welcome variation within a narrative often inclined to provide explicit moral

answers. It acknowledges that a correct inscription does not in itself create a secure place for the person whose name it preserves.

Water Sinks into the Earth and Becomes Roots

The enchanted pond slowly sinks into the soil. Burhba observes that liberation does not always mean rising upwards: sometimes it means entering the ground and becoming a root. The image reverses the earlier association of immersion with passive disappearance. Death and the ongoing social labour of preserving names are linked through the figure of rootedness. Yet to treat spiritual release as adequate recompense for actual deaths would obscure the structures that permitted violence. The novel avoids that danger in part by retaining the antagonists' fear and the unfinished duty of remembrance. The root is an image of potential continuity, not a settlement of claims for material and legal redress.

The Different Dreams of Bereaved Families and Rogues

The bereaved dream of bathing without bodies, labour growing lighter and glimpses of home; the antagonists dream of orders becoming crocodiles' jaws, passwords changing into dead people's names and erased messages staining the skin. The two groups of dreams form a parallel design of imagined moral justice. The relatives' dreams are not established grants of compensation or proof of restored livelihoods. Nor are the perpetrators' nightmares the equivalent of full remorse. The novel leaves a distance between symbolic experience and completed human action. The contrast is emotionally forceful because the same night gives the bereaved a possible reprieve and the powerful an experience of vulnerability, without cancelling the asymmetry of their histories.

'One Who Listened' beside Satyavrat's Name

Satyavrat comes to be identified by what he has done—'one who listened'—rather than by his official designation. This renaming is a significant change in the novel's language of characterisation. Institutional title had marked hierarchy; an action-based description makes him an ordinary participant in an act of attention. Yet 'he listened' does not mean that he has delivered a decision or completed assistance. The magical alteration expresses the possibility of accepting institutional responsibility, not its automatic fulfilment. By reducing the prestige attached to his title, the narrative brings him nearer to the voices he formerly approached through documents, while leaving the work of legal response open.

The Uncertain Ending of the Name after the Body

At dawn the game of kabaddi has stopped, but the ground bears footprints of human beings, ghosts, elephant and crocodile. Asked about leaving, Satyavrat indicates an obligation that remains until names find a place on the earth. A leaf moves without wind; the name of the dead body searches for roots. The ending makes memory an active claim upon social space rather than an honour permanently secured by an inscription. Its strength lies in keeping the question ‘freed or dead?’ unresolved. Its limitations are the renewed threshold scene of Satyavrat’s entry across Chapters 48–50 and the increasingly familiar rhythm of supernatural rebuke. The actual future of the names remains uncompleted.

Critical Section 152 | Original Chapter 51 — The Burden of Witnessing

The twenty-second breath · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Difficult Moment of Becoming a Witness

Chapter 51 joins the root imagery of 'The Name after the Body' to the public labour of composing a witness statement. Satyavrat again feels as though he is entering his own chest within Channa Grove. The central opposition is between outward office and inward voice. Listening does not immediately earn him honour: the narrative gives him a heavy body and difficult writing. The accompanying folk song promises shared assistance, rest and safety to a witness; the prose concentrates on Satyavrat's personal responsibility and the community's reading. These are not descriptions of a fully established and equally accessible system of witness protection. Their difference should remain visible in any faithful analysis of the chapter's ethical intentions and narrated actions.

The Ghosts' Circle and Their Changed Roles

The Peepal Brahma sits in silence with four faces; Burhba draws in his dark light; Loth acts as a guard of the archive; Panidubbi appears as a damp line across the ground. In this collective arrangement, the ghosts' previous function as players recedes and their roles as witnesses and guardians become prominent. Each supernatural figure performs a distinct task. Brahma embodies the depth of silence, Burhba questions, Loth guards, and Panidubbi bears the memory of water. They are not interchangeable manifestations of a generic ghost. Attending to this distribution of functions preserves the richness of the novel's local imaginative world. Its community of the dead develops a vocabulary of responsibilities rather than merely repeating an appearance of uncanny beings.

The Darkness of a Seal and the Light of a Name

Satyavrat carries a document stamped with his official seal. Within the grove it is not the seal but the names that shine. The visual hierarchy of authority is reversed. The seal's loss of radiance does not signify that the state has literally lost its legal powers; it marks a symbolic reduction of the prestige attached to office. The more firmly Satyavrat holds onto the visible signs of his position, the more unsettled he becomes by the weight of the names he hears. The rules governing a court's receipt of evidence and the enforceability of its orders do not change through this miracle.

The scene stages the human limitations of official authority, rather than offering a new procedural code.

The Journey of 'Burden' from the Scales to the Chest

Burhba asks Satyavrat whether he has come to carry the burden or merely to weigh it again. The question restores the central figure of 'The Circle of Burden', but the meaning has altered. Chapter 42 weighed the consequences of acts attributable to those implicated in exploitation; here the impact of others' voices rests upon the chest of the person hearing them. To make these burdens identical would be false. A perpetrator's responsibility differs from the exhaustion of someone entrusted with testimony. The song's ideal of shared support is likewise distinct from a fully developed institutional arrangement in the events of the prose. The comparison is fertile only when these differences remain intact.

Bodily Death and the Second Immersion of a Name

The novel gives its title 'water burial' another interpretation. After the consumption or destruction of a body, the state's notation of a person as absent may constitute a second, social death. Satyavrat recognises that his silence may have helped permit such a second immersion. This self-reading of the title is powerful: natural violence, administrative denial and the struggle of memory are brought together. But symbolic rescue of a name cannot compensate for the physical death of a worker or replace a reckoning with administrative wrongdoing. The double burial is a critical metaphor with real human consequences; it is not proof that a spiritual act has repaired the harm described in the opening chapters.

The Crocodile's Teeth in the Plural

Water appears upon the crocodiles' teeth in the grove, rather than blood. Burhba says not every tooth is an instrument of killing: some can cut a bond and permit release. The image frees the governing crocodile metaphor from an exclusively violent sense. Earlier crocodiles marked destruction and exploitation; here their teeth can also serve a liberating action. This transformation amounts to a major rereading of the title's symbolism. Nevertheless, a metaphor's ability to carry more than one meaning must not be used to exonerate actual violence. The novel changes the imaginative function of a figure without withdrawing claims about the wrongs its earlier appearances represented. Its plurality is aesthetic and ethical, not an acquittal.

A Child's Question and Two Languages of Testimony

To Satyavrat, a child's question differs from the court's habitual 'Where is the proof?': if you saw what happened, will you speak? The question

foregrounds the human obligation of a witness. Judicial procedures for the testing of evidence remain distinct and cannot be replaced by a communal question. Equally, an injured memory is not automatically without value because it has not yet entered a court record. The text constructs a tension between two languages of knowing, neither of which should be mechanically substituted for the other. The child asks for social responsibility. The court must still determine the evidentiary standing of what is later placed before it. The scene is strongest when the tension remains productive rather than artificially resolved.

Placing the Nameplate on the Earth

Satyavrat removes the plate bearing his official designation and places it on the ground. This is one of the chapter's most concentrated physical decisions. He does not thereby abandon his legal training, professional labour or institutional existence. He suspends the priority of rank while listening. Moving a single object accomplishes what a long speech might have weakened: the gesture makes room for other people's voices. It would be inaccurate to describe this as a formal resignation from government service. The narrated action concerns a nameplate, not an executed letter or administrative change of employment status. Its modesty is the source of its force as characterisation.

The Witness Statement's Declared First Readers

Satyavrat announces that he will write not a verdict but a witness statement. Children will read it first; questions from the court will come afterwards. The order creates a difficult but significant dialogue between recognition by those affected and the procedures of an institution. Through children's listening, the speech of the community acquires human meaning. Yet a document written in Channa Grove does not automatically become admissible as fully authenticated legal evidence. The narrated events are the writing of the statement and its communal reading. A final judicial order remains another, future matter. The scene honours the audience to whom testimony is first morally answerable without erasing the separate responsibilities of legal proof.

A Victim's Privacy and the Limits of Observed History

Meera asks how stolen privacy can be returned. The Peepal Brahma answers that the drowned cannot be restored, but the next hand capable of harming someone may be stopped. The answer distinguishes an irreversible past from preventive social action. No completed recovery of private materials, removal of every public copy or definitive legal remedy is narrated here. The community's prospective vigilance has ethical value, but it must not be represented as the accomplished repair of Meera's

experience. The text's restraint lies in refusing a false happy ending. Recovering a sense of agency involves protection of future choices, not a magical reversal of every disclosure or injury already suffered.

Ira's Difficulty with a Name in Her Ancestral Language

Ira hesitates while pronouncing 'Garh Narikela'. Ananya takes her hand and asks her to say it slowly. This is an intimate image of language being learned in relation to place. Foreign education and an international platform do not confer immediate mastery of the village's name. Intellectual affiliation with an inherited cultural history is different from the personal practice of speaking its language. But hesitation is not a permanent sign of cultural inferiority. The novel renders both characters' agency in the act of learning: Ira admits difficulty, and Ananya offers assistance without diminishing her. Their interaction deepens the account of belonging beyond a simple opposition between an authentic village and an inauthentic diaspora.

The Crocodiles Retreat: Release or a Crisis Deferred?

After the statement is read, the crocodiles begin moving towards the water. They relinquish their guard over dead bodies and accept the people's guardianship of names. This retreat produces an emotional climax within the supernatural world. Yet no detailed event shows the immediate disappearance of digital fraud, transnational transactions, faulty bridge construction or administrative silence. The image creates an inheritance of vigilance rather than announcing completed economic and judicial justice. The distinction matters because the novel has repeatedly placed spectacular gestures beside slow practical work. Here the crocodiles' withdrawal can indicate a changed moral relation without serving as a verified report of material reparation.

A New Sentence on the Blank Reverse of the Nameplate

Satyavrat turns over the official nameplate he laid in the soil and writes upon its blank reverse: those who have been heard are no longer alone. The emblem of public office becomes a modest writing surface for a promise of human solidarity. A sign once used to establish rank is repurposed to sustain a relationship. Nevertheless, the fact that someone has been heard does not finally abolish their isolation. Assistance, documentary work, privacy safeguards and institutional investigation remain necessary. The sentence is a commitment with obligations, not an audited result. The dignity of the gesture depends on the critic's refusal to turn its future-oriented meaning into a finished achievement.

The Narrative Design of the Burden of Witnessing

Chapter 51 reorganises the crocodile and water-burial imagery around the double possibility of violence and release. The fundamental actions of becoming a witness are small: laying down a nameplate, writing a statement, hearing children read and accepting the duty of guarding names. The chapter's humane strength lies in these incomplete responsibilities. Its limitations include the recurring entrances of Satyavrat into the grove and the increasingly predictable imagery of supernatural rebuke. The next decisive turn moves away from this inward and symbolic trial towards a material struggle: the cutting of the grove itself. That shift tests whether the community's archive can survive damage to the ground that sheltered it.

Critical Section 153 | Original Chapter 52 — The Next Voice

The cutting of Channa Grove · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From Spiritual Release to the Physical Cutting of Trees

At the close of Chapter 51 the crocodiles retreated towards the water, leaving a witness statement in the children's hands. 'The Next Voice' tests this apparently liberating moment against a material and political crisis: the cutting of Channa Grove begins. The novel does not rest upon the declarations of its newly formed school and archive. Their central site of memory is itself being destroyed. The scene shifts attention from metaphorical crocodiles to actual bamboo, rope, axes, official maps and working hands. This is a major event in the plot, not merely another beautiful symbol of redemption. To describe the felling uncritically as the next stage of emancipation would aestheticise an injury to a living place.

The Documentary Power of the Word 'Encroachment'

An official map designates Channa Grove as a site of encroachment. This classification has profound narrative consequences. For villagers the grove contains an inherited court of memory, ghostly games, readings of names and histories of labour. Administrative terminology assigns it a different kind of spatial identity. The narrator exposes the ethical compression involved in such classification. Yet the fact that the map uses the word 'encroachment' does not itself establish whether the actual land-rights records are accurate. The novel does not supply a complete independent verification of title and usage rights. Its depicted conflict concerns the gulf between institutional ways of seeing land and the meanings attached to that land by people who have lived around it.

The First Branch Falls: An Unsettling Arrival of Light

When a thick branch falls, a long beam of light enters the grove. Hidden objects, old cloth and damp crevices among the roots become visible to villagers for the first time. The response is not an uncomplicated joy at the defeat of darkness. Exposure brings shame and discomfort: life once sheltered in shadow is suddenly laid bare. Light does not carry a single moral meaning here. It can make hidden histories available to new viewers while also stripping people and places of the protection of concealment. The scene therefore gives physical damage and increased public visibility mutually contradictory consequences. The emergence of light should not

be converted into the claim that cutting the tree was an unqualified public good.

Differing Village Responses and Communal Polyphony

Some residents welcome the felling as an end to fear, while others grieve the destruction of memory. The village is not represented at the outset as an ideologically uniform resistance movement. People who had feared the haunted place can also see the possibility of daylight within it. This polyphony makes the novel's local community more credible, for attachment to the archive need not erase the earlier divisions of belief and experience. Over time additional voices join the common activity, but the initial differences prevent an easy celebration of collective victory. Narratologically, the mixed response gives the landscape a social history of disagreement rather than a single authorially prescribed meaning.

Satyavrat Returns and Rejects Self-Absolution

Satyavrat sits near a cut root in a plain kurta, carrying a cloth bag rather than arriving with the privileges of official transport. The text says he has come again, and the community understands his quietness in relation to the duty incurred by his earlier silence. Yet the time between this return and his appearances in Chapters 50–51 is not made sufficiently clear. A critic may consider a recurrent inward arrival or a narrative discontinuity, but should not supply invented dates to close the gap. What is clear about the character is his refusal to presume himself absolved. The new physical setting tests his conduct, while his personal chronology remains less precisely articulated.

The Smell of the Cut Root and the Labourer's Tool

As the final large limb is severed, the wood smells not of rot but of damp earth, sunlight, old paper and children's hair. The worker handling the axe stops momentarily. In this sensory composition, the tree's body becomes a bearer of generational memory. An important distinction is embedded within the scene: the labourer who swings the axe is not necessarily the author of the administrative decision or a beneficiary of it. Ownership, instructions, manual execution and local opposition occupy different levels of power. The suspended axe invites the reader to notice those differences. The novel's concern for labour should prevent criticism from collapsing the person carrying out an order into the institution that issued it.

Falling Shade and Growing Access: A Paradox

As the canopy recedes, access to the site increases. Carts come by day, women bring lamps in the evening, young people take photographs and

boatmen call out. The loss has a difficult partial consequence: communal memory becomes visible to people who previously did not enter the grove. The old enclosure and its magical privacy diminish, while a more public site of remembrance begins to form. The narrative does not treat destruction as inevitable progress. Grief for the tree and civic activity in its newly exposed space coexist. The time of the tree's survival and the widening circulation of names are different processes, even when they belong to the same history.

Crocodiles Return from the Edge of Memory

The crocodiles appear again, not as identifiable animals rising from the pond but as uncertain presences at the edge of people's remembrance. The narrator frames the encounter within unstable collective experience rather than as a specimen caught and verified. Water burial retains its double meaning: bodily destruction and the possibility of release from social erasure. The return of the supernatural crocodile does not explain the administrative act that led to the cutting. Those belong to different levels of narrative knowledge. A critic should keep the apparition's symbolic and emotional force distinct from the documents, property classifications and orders governing the physical site.

The Children's Proposal: A New Tree, the Old Names

A girl touches the severed stump and asks whether another tree can be planted. One child wants old names beneath new shade; another imagines an open gathering place for listening. Collective grief begins to become communal planning. None of these proposals should be reported as completed replanting, the growth of a mature canopy or an approved new use of the land. They remain plans and hopes expressed at the site of loss. The living community steps forward as a central agent of the narrative, but the dispute over administrative control and land rights remains unresolved. The proposed tree speaks to responsibility, not instantaneous ecological recovery.

A Green Point on the Cut Stump

After the final night a minute green point appears along one strip of the stump. Some read it as natural vitality; others call it a miracle. The narrator leaves both interpretations open. This is a comparatively subtle use of magical realism: the small sign does not demand a definitive biological explanation, and the reader's interpretive act becomes central. To announce that a whole tree has already grown again would destroy the slow temporal significance of the image. A tiny green point suggests only the uncertainty and duration of future growth. Chapters 53–54 will

connect that sign to the community's effort to create a new social space around what survives.

A Public Gathering and the Retreat of the Individual Hero

No one offers Satyavrat ceremonial reverence. His return is understood as a debt of listening. People gather at the site and read the names of those who have been lost. The principal scene is no longer the dramatic conversion of an eminent legal official; it is the ordinary action of the community. This can accurately be called the beginning of an open gathering place, but not the completed establishment of a legally protected memorial or fully constituted civic body. The novel's broad social metaphor is being made through the labour of living people. The changed position of a single prominent listener assists that development without superseding it.

The Incompleteness of the Cutting and Narrative Time

Near the end, the grove is described as 'half-cut', although an earlier passage mentioned the felling of the last large limb. The distinction might be between a branch and the whole rooted body, but the source requires care. What is securely shown is a surviving stump, severed branches and exposed roots. The ending of one phase of the tree's life is not declared the complete death of its entire living structure. This remnant becomes the centre of the next civic scene. The minor discrepancy of description should be recorded, not forcibly removed. The retained wood permits the narrative to move from the time of cutting to the slower time of care.

Public Visibility and the First Shadow of the Market

Mobile-phone photographs, outside visitors, tea carts and increased traffic enlarge the audience for the site's history. Yet that very visibility may make memory an object of commerce or renewed administrative control. The unfamiliar observers in Chapter 53 and the subsequent notice extend this possibility into a new plot. Taking a photograph is not by itself a wrongful act. The question is whether the autonomy of the people remembering their dead can be converted into an entrance fee, a beautification scheme or a profitable development project. The novel plants this conflict before the anticipated institutional action arrives, linking a gain in public attention to a new vulnerability.

Overall Assessment: The Tree Tests the Narrative of Liberation

The chapter's most important achievement is its turn from the magically mediated admissions of Chapters 47–51 towards the tangible danger of a tree being cut. Lost shade, the embarrassment of exposure, a remaining stump, the arrival of outsiders and a green speck bear mutually resistant meanings. The critical qualification is indispensable: the destruction of the

grove cannot simply be relabelled communal liberation. Channa Grove was a living historical place, and the ecological cost of its injury cannot be waived by calling it a powerful symbol. Hope and realised action, increased accessibility and the loss of a tree, remain distinct. This refusal of a simple resolution gives the next phase of the narrative its material urgency.

Critical Section 154 | Original Chapter 53 — Morning after the Cutting

The daylight watch · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

The Shame of Daylight after the Cutting

Chapter 53 opens with an unfamiliar unease. The canopy whose darkness had protected stories for generations has been removed, exposing the place directly to the sun. The trunk is almost compared to the suddenly uncovered body of an elderly woman. Sunlight is therefore not merely a symbol of freedom; it also produces the vulnerability of being exposed. The narrative gives the site a new character by allowing the environment itself to become an object of scrutiny and discomfort. Light does not arrive to declare all old beliefs defeated. It reveals a living space that must now be interpreted—and possibly exploited—by people who had not seen it in this state. The scene holds visual revelation together with shame.

Rings in the Felled Tree: Reading Biological Time

Dark and pale growth rings are visible on the circular surface of the stump; Burhba begins counting them. Natural time is recorded in the tree's body, while the names of dead labourers remained absent from institutional lists. His parallel reflection proposes that after the 'cutting' of human lives, their names too must be opened to view. The image establishes a distinctive relationship among biological duration, social history and administrative forgetting. The source does not, however, give an exact count of calendar years for the rings. A critic must not introduce speculative dates or additional scientific observations to create the appearance of precision. The power of the scene comes from comparing distinct forms of memory without forcing them into one chronology.

The Day Watch and the Limits of the Ghosts' Nightly Role

Children begin guarding the site by day, carrying the notebook of names, while the ghosts' game retains its place at night. This is a fundamental transfer of social responsibility. The supernatural justice of the dead continues alongside the ordinary work of the living, but does not replace it. The disappearance of shade does not render the ghosts altogether inactive. It changes the time and use of the site. The two communities occupy different temporal forms of agency, although the children's activities are becoming more publicly visible. The scene advances the novel's repeated movement from haunted remembrance towards collective acts that can be continued under daylight.

The Rule that Stops Play When a Name-Stone Moves

Stones bearing names are placed beside the kabaddi line. If one is knocked out of place, play must stop until it is returned. The memory of a person takes precedence over competitive victory. Instead of catching a player who crosses the boundary, the others ask that player for a name. The violent grasp associated with the crocodile and the mythic struggle becomes a question used in social education. Yet this rule within the children's game does not by itself produce a permanent legal right to occupy a public site. It is an exercise in locally agreed conduct, not a land title. The contrast between the ethical regulation of play and the unsettled institutional protection of the grove will soon become crucial.

Devika's Fuller Identification of 'Ujjwal Kumar Jha'

Devika places a hand on the stone bearing Ujjwal's name and writes a sentence connecting his personal tragedy, the fraud network and the experience of being left alone. Earlier the name generally appeared as 'Ujjwal Jha'; here it is expanded to 'Ujjwal Kumar Jha'. The fuller form may be ordinary variation, but it does not resolve the different descriptions of his death recorded in earlier chapters. Her hand shakes because placing a personal name within a public account of causes opens the wound of bereavement anew. The private tempo of mourning and the public tempo of preventive education proceed together without becoming identical. The gesture belongs to the family's voice, not to an impersonal act of classification.

Meera's 'Right to Silence'

Meera places a distinct symbol of privacy on a name-stone. Her rule is to listen to those who want to speak and protect the silence of those who choose not to. This is a vital internal revision of the preceding argument about a 'record of silence'. If every silence were treated as blameworthy, a victim's refusal to disclose intimate information could itself become the basis for renewed violence. Meera draws a clear boundary between voluntary privacy and institutional erasure. The resulting position is more mature than an unconditional demand to register all silences. The community's commitment to memory must be limited by the affected person's authority over whether and how a private story is told.

Ira Closes Her Notebook

Ira arrives by a night bus after the cutting. Seeing the grove laid bare, she opens her notebook and then closes it: she must look and listen before writing. The scholar who once challenged the language of a foreign lecture hall now sits at a materially damaged local site. The gesture checks the prominence of the articulate intellectual narrator. Ira also refrains

from offering an immediate answer to the question of names erased in other countries. Her admission of uncertainty is significant for the novel's management of knowledge. Research, in this scene, begins by respecting what has not yet been understood. The closed notebook is not a rejection of documentation, but a choice about the ethical order in which experience and inscription should proceed.

Satyavrat's Absence and the Presence of His Debt

Chapter 52 brought Satyavrat to the site of the cutting, but he is absent on the morning of Chapter 53. The children write that the listener is absent while the debt remains. These may simply be two different moments in time; a temporary absence does not necessarily establish a textual contradiction. More importantly, the character's obligation survives his bodily departure. The novel does not keep the transformed official permanently at the centre of its stage. The children continue the daytime watch, and their work possesses its own continuity. Responsibility is not discharged by one notable visit, nor does the community need the continual visible presence of a prestigious figure to maintain its archive.

From Invisible Chairmanship to Everyday Work

Water jars, a temporary cloth shelter, a circle of lime, swept sand and a chisel for deepening names on stone become the visible equipment of the new site. There is no ceremonial inauguration, chairman or ribbon to be cut. These modest details constitute some of the chapter's most credible signs of social reorganisation. The proclaimed people's justice becomes the actual labour of maintaining a provisional memorial. Participation is tested by upkeep rather than by spectacular statements of reverence. Yet the place is not legally secured. Its improvised arrangements remain vulnerable to the municipal notice that will arrive shortly. The narrative's realism lies in the exposure of a functioning community project to administrative power.

Burhba's Thinning Body in Sunlight

In daylight Burhba's dark ghostly form becomes thin. Hulasi fears he may disappear, but he explains the change as an adjustment of eyes accustomed to darkness. This supernatural language figures the reduction of the past's exclusive authority and the possibility of independent sight for the next generation. Burhba no longer seeks to remain the only judge of a shadowy court. The episode does not confirm his final dissolution: at evening his shape grows more substantial again. His changing visibility registers a redistributed role in the story, not an unequivocal end to his existence. The ghosts persist while the responsibility for public memory passes increasingly into living hands.

Unknown Inspectors and the Entrance of the Market

Two unidentified men stand outside the grove and discuss the regular crowds and the possibility of a ‘project’ while using a mobile phone. The narrator does not provide their full identities. Panidubbi senses the smell of the market. Their presence offers a clear anticipation of commercial intervention in a site whose public visibility is rapidly growing. Still, the men cannot be definitively identified as employees of any particular organisation, nor is a development contract shown to have been approved. The reader acquires a little more knowledge than the children guarding the names, and this difference creates suspense. Public remembrance has attracted new attention, but the purposes of that attention are not yet transparent.

The Daytime Rhythm of ‘Present, Present’

During the evening kabaddi game the children call ‘Present, present’ instead of repeating the traditional word for the game. The opposing team listens rather than seizing the player who crosses the line. A small alteration of verbal rhythm makes a substantial difference in meaning. The breath of play now marks the community’s recognition of names and of one another. What began as a supernatural contest among ghosts has become a public exercise conducted by living children. Rather than claiming that everyone has become a victor, the narrator focuses on the rule that makes collective attention possible. The change in speech demonstrates how a ritual can be reworked into civic training without abandoning its inherited form.

The First Yellow Paper and the Time of Notice

At the chapter’s close a watchman runs up carrying a yellow municipal paper, and a stamped notice is fixed to the stump. This is the direct beginning of the next administrative confrontation. Panidubbi had already sensed the arrival of the market, but the precise contents of the notice are not yet opened fully. Chapter 54 also presents a postmaster arriving with a yellow envelope. Are these two different communications or two presentations in a partially obscured sequence? The source does not supply an adequate connecting explanation. It would be wrong to invent a number of letters or an exact chronology simply to remove that uncertainty. The arrival of the paper matters because it introduces the time of official action into the time of communal remembrance.

Overall Assessment: The Social Value of Morning

‘Morning after the Cutting’ describes the slow practical work that follows the loss of the tree’s shade. Growth rings, Devika’s trembling inscription, Meera’s right to silence, Ira’s closed notebook, Burhba’s thinning body

and the unfamiliar interest in a possible project each perform a different narrative function. The chapter's principal strength lies less in overt moral declarations than in the bodily and social acts through which characters develop. Its pace moves rather quickly from the novelty of daylight towards a municipal dispute, but the transformation of ghostly kabaddi into shared public work remains convincing. The result is neither a finished memorial nor an uncomplicated recovery. It is an exposed institution in the making.

Critical Section 155 | Original Chapter 54 — Around the Stump

The public gathering and the yellow envelope · Narratological criticism of the original Maithili text

From a Court of Darkness to a Gathering in Daylight

At the start of Chapter 54 villagers sit in a circle around the stump of the cut Channa tree. The former court of ghosts depended on darkness and uncanny voices; here sunlight, exposed roots and the reading aloud of names establish a gathering of the living. Aruni experiences it as more court-like than the court, because every face listens carefully without a stage, lawyer, chairman or official signature. The scene does not replicate the functioning of a judicial institution. It gives community testimony an independent spatial form. Its collective character is created by the attention of people physically present, not by an order issued by one hero or the assumption of a single supernatural authority.

Exposed Roots and the Public Life of Secrets

The cutting reveals damp soil, scraps of a veil, buried objects and hidden recesses in the wood. Sunlight is compared with an unsparing surgical knife; the stump resembles the exposed chest of an elderly body. The imagery questions the assumption that daylight must always be morally purifying. Discovering a hidden object does not automatically make it material that anyone is entitled to seize or display. Ananya insists that people listen before lifting things out of the stump. The chapter thereby introduces a necessary restraint into the relation among material remains, memory and public exhibition. A discovered object has a history, a context and possibly an owner; its sudden visibility is not sufficient grounds for appropriation.

‘Listen First’: Ananya’s Rule of Guardianship

Children initially approach the contents of the stump as treasure and want to remove them. Ananya stops them: they must first listen. The former player’s role as guardian of the register of names becomes more settled. This rule also corrects the earlier tendency to assume that anything connected with remembrance should immediately be made public. The remains of the tree are historical materials, but consent, context and the character of the source are needed to understand their meaning. Ananya’s sentence functions as a procedure for the community’s gathering. It does not make the child omniscient; its value lies in establishing how people must proceed precisely because they do not yet know enough.

Ba Touches the Root and the Community Mourns

Ba's eyesight is failing, yet she knows how to reach the stump. She touches the root, remains silent for a long time and then voices the hope that shade may be born again. The scene recognises forms of knowledge other than sight: embodied habit, touch and memory of a familiar place. But the statement that surviving roots may produce new shade belongs to the future tense. The tree has not been shown growing back to maturity, nor has the municipality rescinded its decision. Ba does not deny the loss before her. She makes listening and a possible new narrative bearable within it. Her bodily knowledge grounds hope while preventing the absent canopy from becoming an already restored fact.

Burhba's Shimmer in Daylight

Burhba is not usually visible with clarity by day, but here he appears like a shimmer of dust. The narration is careful: several people later claim to have seen a dark figure, but not everyone witnesses the same distinct apparition. This differentiation of focalisation matters. The narrator's supernatural world coexists with the varying testimony of people who remember or interpret events in different ways. The children's quietness signals that Burhba has not returned to issue another unilateral judgment. He comes to watch the living practise listening. The scene preserves the ghost's imaginative presence without treating all subsequent claims of sight as identical first-hand observation.

The Trembling Voice of an Ageing Labourer's Son

The first name is read by the son of a worker, now an old man himself. He trembles like a child as he speaks his father's name. Air passes through a cavity in the stump; some hear breathing and others attribute the sound to an insect. The children write that the name was heard and the stump answered. The distinction between sensory occurrence and communal interpretation is essential. A sound is part of the narrated scene; identifying it as a dead father's answer belongs to the local interpretation of that sound. The critic should not combine them into an obligatory factual conclusion. The ageing son's voice allows the buried time of an earlier worker to emerge in the present gathering.

Ujjwal's Mother and Devika's Deliberately Slow Reading

Ujjwal's mother reads his name quietly. Devika places a hand upon her shoulder and assures her that there is no need to hurry. A bird calls three times. The authority to pronounce the name rests here with the bereaved mother; Devika assists rather than replacing her voice. The bird's call may acquire the meaning of a reply within local interpretation, but it does not settle the conflicting accounts of Ujjwal's death in earlier chapters. The

narrator slows the tempo of public reading to accommodate the time required by personal grief. The community's most important action is not to obtain an immediate statement but to accept the family's pace and the vulnerability of its speech.

Signs of Nature as a Supernatural Archive

The children decide to record the wind, birds, sunlight, barking dogs, a cough or drops of water after each name is read. This expands the older image of letters appearing spontaneously on leaves into a more varied record of natural responses. Yet the occurrence of a natural sound does not verify a person's identity or determine a cause of death. The story is making a social experience of connection. Its folk-script has poetic value, provided the uncertainty of its sources is preserved. Magical realism must not be installed in the place of forensic evidence or treated as a scientific certification of the villagers' claims. The different kinds of knowing coexist without becoming the same.

Saumya's Consent-Based Decision Not to Write

Saumya, once accustomed to recording everything she heard, now enters material only beside the names whose families want it recorded. Respect for an experience left unwritten is an unusually important development. After the urgency of recording all silences in Chapter 49, the novel recognises a further ethical limit. Some silence results from the suppression of a person's history; some silence is the rightful privacy chosen by someone exposed to danger. Saumya's closed notebook is an act of character growth. The reliability of an archive may depend not only on what it gathers, but also on what it deliberately refrains from collecting without permission.

Red Thread, Name-Stones and the Foregrounding of Incompleteness

Meera brings red thread, stipulating that stones bearing names should be placed around the stump without turning grief into a spectacle. Some stones have complete names, others fragments, and still others only signs. The stone for 'one whose name has not been found' is placed first. The right of the unknown thus precedes even the orderly honour given to identified people. The arrangement is not a grand monument claiming to have completed every record. It is a public admission of incomplete knowledge. Inventing a name to fill an unknown entry would violate the narrative's method. The stone's leading position makes the archive's missing information visible without pretending that loss has become fully legible.

Gop's Papers and the Site of the Stump: Two Archives

Gop still possesses many copies, lists and coded files. The place of public gathering around the stump teaches him that paper can preserve indications of a name, people can carry voices, the stump can provide a place and children can maintain the watch. The archive is therefore plural in its media. Documentary copies, public listening and a physical site of remembrance complement one another, while none is omniscient. Gop's actual contribution is to recognise this difference, not to fill every unknown column of his digital tables instantaneously. The narrative avoids both the romantic dismissal of records and the technocratic assumption that a database alone can restore the social life of the persons recorded.

Satyavrat's Agency in Standing at the Back

Satyavrat has not been summoned, yet he listens from a distance. When a child invites him to sit, he does not immediately occupy the centre of the gathering. He leaves the place of names in the foreground. His earlier gesture of laying his official nameplate on the soil is now expressed as social conduct rather than a symbolic act alone. This is not permanent religious self-renunciation. The practical responsibilities associated with his public office may still be essential to the community's needs. The narrator simply moves a prominent official slightly away from the stage, allowing the voices of ordinary victims and relatives to occupy more of the narrative space.

The Postmaster Arrives with a Yellow Envelope

A postmaster cycles along a short path and delivers a yellow envelope bearing the municipal seal to Aruni. Ananya decides that the letter will not be opened in the middle of the reading of names, and it remains upon the stump through the night. The event is a deliberate postponement, showing the gathering's choice of priorities. Yet Chapter 53 had already shown a watchman affixing a notice to the stump. The original does not explain clearly whether this envelope is another communication or a repeated presentation of an initial notice. A critic should not invent a tidy number and order of letters. The delay works dramatically even while the documentary continuity is uncertain.

Overall Assessment: The Architecture of a Place for Listening

'Around the Stump' transforms the pain of cutting into a social architecture of circles, roots, stones, names, red thread, silence and open sky. The narrative does not announce the construction of a grand new building; its strongest image is an ongoing community gathering without a chairman. A possible weakness is the temptation to read every sound of

nature as a definitive response from the dead, reducing the uncertainty of the events. Saumya's restraint in leaving some experience unwritten and the priority given to the stone of the unidentified provide valuable counterweights. The unopened yellow envelope plants a dramatic conflict with institutional power. The site of listening has formed, but its security is not settled.

Critical Section 156 | Original Chapter 55 — The Municipality's Yellow Notice

From the Waiting Envelope to Formal Confrontation

The yellow envelope that has lain overnight at the edge of the stump is opened at dawn in Chapter 55. The formal significance of this event is considerable: the reading of names comes first, the administrative letter afterwards—an order of priorities determined by the people's assembly. The municipality's blue seal, the three sheets inside and the cold language of officialdom move the narrative from a site of supernatural remembrance towards a concrete dispute over land. Within the metaphor of yellow wings, the sound of scissors anticipates violence enacted through policy. Yet the issuing of a notice is not the same as the final legal force of an order; no immediate use of force takes place.

The Three-Page Structure of the Scene

The first page gives notice of 'public beautification and road safety'; the second contains a map showing an empty square in place of the grove; the third is a form seeking name, address, grounds, evidence and ownership. The narrative thus distinguishes three functions of the paper: the language of policy, the representation of territory and the procedural conditions for a reply. This is a description of the material content of an administrative act; it must not be dissolved into the same category as the supernatural conversations of the crocodiles. Nor is the administrative document automatically proved false. What demands examination is the effect of its classifications and the voices omitted from them.

The Struggle over the Definition of the 'General Public'

The notice argues that the movement of the general public, lighting, cleanliness and amenities will improve. Devika asks whether mothers who read names, sons of the dead and children who have kept vigil do not belong to this 'general public'. Her question brings the universal claim of policy language face to face with particular human bodies. Nevertheless, the real need for road safety or sanitation is not impossible or false merely because it is expressed by the government. The specific conflict in the novel concerns the possibility that the affected community has been excluded from the map and the hearing on the plan. Narratologically, its force lies in the opposition between abstract public interest and the names of living people.

The Accusation of Superstition and Meera's Response

The notice mentions the possibility of tension arising from unverified stories, crowds and superstition. Meera counters by pointing to the social value of the spoken remembrance of names and the protection of privacy. This confrontation separates the meanings of the actual supernatural narrative and a civic vigil conducted in public. Even though the grove contains tales of ghosts playing kabaddi, public education about the privacy of survivors, the names of workers and bank fraud is not, in itself, superstition. Equally, not every governmental investigation of a claim rooted in popular belief can universally be called unjustified violence. The distinction between sources and the rights of affected persons remain essential.

The Form's Questions and the Impossible Answers of the Absent

Gop reads the boxes on the third page: name, ownership, address and proof. How will the voices of those whose bodies have disappeared into the water, whose names have vanished through fraud, or whose papers have been taken away enter these boxes? This is a profound narrative question posed to the ordinary formalities of an administrative form. Yet Gop does not throw it away; he places it beside the register. That action reveals an important restraint in resistance. To demand an accounting of people's names within official language, rather than rejecting every documentary exchange in a single gesture, is a more mature expression of the novel's ethics of the archive.

Satyavrat's Suspicion: Fact and Inference

Satyavrat suspects that the notice is not solely a municipal draft: legal specialists, a memorial project and interests associated with contracts may be operating behind it. This should be understood as a character's suspicion informed by institutional experience, not as independent proof of a definite conspiracy. The narrator immediately introduces an emissary of Batuknath, increasing the narrative plausibility of that suspicion. Yet the text does not provide a complete chain identifying who drafted this particular notice, which officer signed it, or which scheme had been approved. Criticism must keep the allegation, the suspicion and the emissary's actual proposal distinct.

The Ornamental Memorial Presented by Batuknath's Emissary

An emissary in white trousers and a blue kurta displays a colour-printed design: a gate, plaques, a ticket office, a gallery of remembrance, a visitors' book and a planned assembly hall. The proposal enters under the language of outward respect, but risks converting the autonomy of communal memory into a negotiable project. The emissary's image is not an already

constructed memorial; it is a presentation and a proposal. It would be premature to claim, from a picture of a ticket office, that the site of remembrance has already been sold in its entirety. The narrative tension concerns the proposal's social accountability.

Ananya's Question about the Missing Stone

Ananya asks where, in the emissary's coloured design, the stone for 'the one whose name has not been found' will stand. He offers a language of symbolic inclusion. The children also ask where mothers will sit and whether the community will retain the freedom to guard the names. The questions produce a sharp inversion within the plot: what an institutionally organised memorial might consign to the decoration of an 'anonymous' inscription, the children give first place. The scene exposes the difference between hierarchical memorial construction and the autonomous communal life of remembrance. The question of the stone reveals the ethical incompleteness of the emissary's attractive design.

The Rebuttal to 'Children Do Not Understand the Law'

The emissary dismisses the children's questions as ignorance of the law. Satyavrat intervenes: law does not belong only to people who understand papers; the voices of those affected must be heard. His earlier training in listening is here carried into institutional reasoning. Yet he neither sets aside a formal government order nor pronounces a court judgment. A character with legal experience makes an ethical argument about people's right to be heard. This is another phase in the motif of resistance to procedure without participation, not a complete institutional victory.

The People's Reply in the Margins of the Yellow Notice

On a blank margin Aruni writes, 'Not vacant land—a place of names'; Devika writes, 'Not a crowd—families'; Meera adds, 'Not superstition—remembrance with privacy'; and Gop contributes further meanings. This is a characteristic technique of rewriting: a one-way official letter becomes a polyphonic text in the hands of the people. Thumbprints, lines and impressions of leaves register participation through different forms of literacy. But writing a reply in the margins does not establish that a formal objection has been filed. At this moment the narrative creates a language of public response; the administrative outcome still awaits determination.

The Return of 'Present'

Voices rise from the gathering, one after another, saying 'Present'. During the earlier reading of names, the word was the community's response in remembrance of the dead; now it becomes the position of living families before an official scheme for the use of land. A word changes its meaning

in the new circumstances of an event. The recurrence is significant because the novel does not merely repeat an old symbol unchanged: its verbal craft makes it an instrument of a new institutional objection. Even so, a collective declaration of presence does not establish universal legal title to the land. It asserts the right of affected people to demand a hearing.

The Seven-Day Threat and a New Rigidity of Time

The emissary leaves with a warning: 'Remove it within seven days, or force will be used.' The narrative now moves from an indeterminate symbolic future to a practical conflict governed by a fixed deadline. Until this point some events have unfolded across centuries, many breaths or endless waiting; the seven-day limit increases the urgency of social decision-making. But force has not yet been used here: it is a possible future action announced by the emissary. Narratologically, the severity of the deadline recreates concrete suspense for the reader.

The First Night of the People's Counter-Map

After the threat, the children do not chase the emissary. Aruni brings a mat, Gop paper, Devika red earth and Meera black charcoal. Ba insists that the map be made not merely by eyes that see the place but by hands that have listened to it. The stump becomes the centre, and Ananya draws a red circle. This collective agency is the chapter's strongest event: the actual beginning of a new cartography in opposition to the yellow paper. The map is not yet complete; only its first mark has been made. The next chapter is thus charged with the expectation that a social geography will unfold.

Overall Assessment: The Map of Words against the Life of a Place

The force of 'The Municipality's Yellow Notice' is that it brings a magical rite of remembrance into collision with the official language of land use, a private proposal for a memorial, the response of affected families and an exact seven-day deadline. The people's pencil inscriptions, questions and red circle alter control over the medium of expression. An important limit is that complete facts about the notice's legal validity and the beneficiaries behind the project are unavailable. Criticism therefore does not mistake the emissary's proposal for a completed scheme, the seven-day threat for violence already carried out, or the writing in the margins for a formally submitted objection. The next major axis of the narrative is the process of making a civic map of the actual place.

Inter-Sectional Conclusion: The Narrative Junction of Chapters 48–55

From the unfinished cry in the crocodile-and-elephant game of the eighteenth breath to the empty bowl of the nineteenth, the ledger of

silence of the twentieth, the watery form of the name beyond the body, the making of a witness-document, the felling of Channa Grove, the dawn after the cutting, the people's meeting around the stump and the municipality's yellow notice, a new movement of the narrative is formed. The first four chapters concentrate more closely on an inward ethical discipline of listening; the following four concern place, memorials, administration, the benefits of proposed schemes and material erasure. The novel's central subject does not change in this sequence; the ground on which it is tested changes. Once the guardianship of names passes into the hands of a living community, a struggle begins over external control of the physical place of remembrance.

Satyavrat Mehta's sequence as a character includes his inward acknowledgment, the call of the bell, the journey in an ordinary railway compartment, arrival at the grove without a title, preparation of the ledger of silence and the act of placing his nameplate on the earth. Yet Chapters 48–52 do not fully reconcile the time and place of his arrival and re-entry into the grove. Criticism does not invent a precise itinerary: it preserves both the possibility of a cyclical ethical return and the difficulty of textual continuity. The question whether Gaj was freed or died, the contradictory identification of Sarayu Devi/Sarayu Mahato as woman or father, and differences in the early accounts of Ujjwal's death likewise remain unresolved.

An indispensable critical distinction is that 'silence' is not a fault everywhere. Devika's grief-stricken self-examination, Munna's fear, Meera's autonomous silence of privacy, the bank employee's turning a blind eye, Satyavrat's institutional silence and the calculated concealment of profiteering networks are separate narrative experiences. Reading the ledger of silence in Chapter 49 alongside Meera's 'right to silence' in Chapter 53 and Saumya's unwritten memories in Chapter 54 yields a more mature criticism. The novel itself subjects these apparently conflicting ethical principles to examination; one pronouncement cannot settle all their meanings.

Channa Grove after the felling constitutes a striking reorganisation of narrative space. From thick darkness, the endless canopy of leaves and the ghosts' nocturnal kabaddi, remembrance spreads into daytime name-stones, chalk lines, a water vessel, temporary shelters, red thread and the assembly around the stump. But cutting a tree is environmental damage. To call the destruction of the tree automatically beneficial because the community's public life has expanded would negate the ecological strand of the narrative. The emissary's coloured presentation for a new memorial project represents another form of the same danger: the commercial collection of communal memory. Ananya's question about the stone for

'the one whose name has not been found' is the most concentrated civic reply to this form of control.

In Chapter 53 the watchman pastes a municipal notice on the stump; in Chapter 54 the postmaster brings a sealed yellow envelope, which is opened in Chapter 55. It is not entirely clear whether the same notice arrived by two routes or whether one letter followed the other. Given the significance of the novel's struggle over actual paperwork, this distinction in continuity matters to criticism. The seven-day threat in Chapter 55 still concerns the possible future use of force; the first red mark of the counter-map has actually been made, but the map itself is not complete.

The strongest narrative moments in this group are of three kinds: Satyavrat's condition of listening before the bowl, Saumya's decision not to write without a survivor's consent, and the people's replies on the margin of the yellow notice. In each case, the power to speak moves away from unilateral authority. The chief narratological achievement of these eight chapters is therefore the gradual development of the question 'Who has the right to tell the story?' into 'Who will be heard?', 'Whose experience will be written?' and 'Who will draw the map of the place?' The analysis rests on narrative time, focalisation, the distribution of voices, the difference between folk song and prose, magical realism, spatial symbolism and textual inconsistency. No invented external event or Navya-Nyāya analysis of evidence has been added.

Critical Section 157 | Original Chapter 56 — The First Map of Memory

The Narrative Emergence of a Counter-Map from the Seven-Day Threat

In Chapter 55 the municipality's classification of the site as 'vacant land' and its seven-day warning demanded an answer from the villagers. Chapter 56 turns that unspecified resistance into visible work. Ananya first straightens the name-stones; Aruni brings the papers of the old bridge project, and the children turn them over to draw the people's lines. Choosing the blank reverse of the official documents is meaningful: the site's existing technical representation has not been erased; the unwritten history of those not heard begins to be recorded on its other side. Resistance here is not a public slogan but the collective labour of making a map.

The Classification of Vacant Land versus the Density of Names

The municipality's paper calls the place empty, while name-stones, the expectation of the dead and the people's old pathways have gathered around the stump. The clash between the administrative category 'empty' and the communal meaning 'full' provides the chapter's principal narrative impetus. Yet acknowledging the general significance of spaces left empty is also practical: where no name is found, a point is left open on the map. This accepts a real uncertainty; it is not permission to fill every vacant box with a new name according to desire. The incompleteness of the archive takes visible form.

The People's Lines on the Reverse of the Bridge Plan

The old foreign contractor's plan included pillars, width, cost, water flow and approach roads. On its reverse the people mark the stump, stones, footpaths, river, settlement and the place of the missing receipt. Two sides of the same sheet embody two systems of narration: the measuring gaze of capital and construction, and the spatial gaze of the memories of the living and the dead. The novelist makes the map a collective narrator. Yet the emotional importance of the people's lines does not wholly replace actual boundaries, area measurements or court-supervised surveys. The relationship between these two forms of representation remains a matter of dispute.

Red Circles, Ash and Dried Leaves as a Material Language

Ananya draws a deep-red circle at the centre of the stump; Meera brings red earth, Devika ash and Ira dried leaves. These substances lend the map different meanings through the personal histories of the characters. Red earth can be read in terms of injury and contact with the land; ash, of death and surviving memory; leaves, of the grove's former living language. Such an interpretation arises from the objects in the scene; the source contains no fixed, authenticated list of colour codes. The making of the map remains collective, even while each substance's voice emerges through a particular character's hands.

The Trembling Line of the Kamala-Balan

Aruni does not draw the river as a straight line. His line touches old fields, workers' homes, bridge foundations and the dark whirlpool before reaching the stump. A child asks why the line trembles. Aruni's answer transforms the river from a line in a file into a river with a body. This spatial description is an unusual 'emotional map': the river remains part of actual geography while recalling the injury to human bodies. The wavering line, however, is not a literal survey of the river's natural course. Its narrative function is to indicate an unfinished history of deaths.

'Mother's Path' and the Reinscription of a Lost Footpath

With her fingernail, Ba draws an old footpath that her mother used to take to the pond. The route has changed on the ground, but the practised movement remains preserved in maternal memory. The children name it 'Mother's Path'. Here the distinction between the disappearance of a geographical feature and the presence of memory is finely drawn. A footpath absent from a current road map is given a place in the history of habitual movement. But the full legal right of passage and the precise line of ownership are not established by this fingernail mark. The narrative opens the archive without completing its findings.

The Last Location of Ujjwal's Phone and Meera's Boundary

Ujjwal's mother draws a black circle around the place where his phone was last found active; Devika adds a light ring of ash. Meera prevents the 'mark of death' from becoming a spectacle. A white point is then marked within the circle. This scene represents collective self-restraint over the right to make the details of grief public. A phone's last recorded activity does not establish the entire sequence of locations associated with a death; the inconsistencies among earlier images of Ujjwal's death are not automatically resolved here. The bereaved family's consent sets the boundary.

A Settlement of Palms: The Different Losses of Different Homes

Saumya questions the families of labourers who disappeared during the bridge works. Rather than rendering the workers' settlement as identical rectangular houses, they draw distinct palms. The number of fingers varies, because each loss has a different form. This is an exceptionally powerful metaphor. An administrative list may reduce citizens' homes to uniform units, whereas a palm becomes the sign of a living body's particular history. Through these lines the novelist creates a plurality of unanswered family griefs; one cannot infer a person's complete biography from the shape of an individual palm.

The 'Hole' Left by a Missing Receipt

Gop remembers a receipt that disappeared near the foreign company's temporary warehouse. The children ask what symbol could stand for missing paper. Gop makes a small hole in the ash. This is an accomplished narrative use of 'negative space': where the fact is absent, absence itself is made visible. The new map does not conceal the lack of a document; that lack becomes a site of inquiry. Caution is needed: Gop's account constitutes personal knowledge of a missing receipt. The receipt's actual contents, amount and the identity of whoever removed it are not thereby established.

The Employees' Measuring Tape and the Ghost's Invisible Signature

Two municipal employees arrive with yellow paint, a measuring tape and stakes to mark the site. Ananya asks whose name or whose mother's path a stake will pierce. In this direct encounter, the people's map confronts the state's act of measurement. The elderly ghost becomes almost visible in daylight; the employees do not see him, and the tape rolls itself up. The narrator distributes visual knowledge unequally: the children's supernatural understanding differs from the employees' experience. The tape's contraction does not mean that the official survey has been formally cancelled.

'Awaiting Identification' versus 'Empty': A Public Politics of Meaning

For the unnamed point Ananya chooses the word 'awaiting identification'. This precise linguistic change reverses the institutional reading of emptiness. Failure to find a name is not final absence but a sign that the search continues. Satyavrat Mehta is a modest listener here; the child's word becomes the possibility of a written public ethic. Yet 'awaiting identification' does not by itself establish every fact concerning a missing person's existence, future identification or cause of death. Language keeps the ethical search alive; it does not manufacture a conclusive result.

The Demand to Add the Sky and the Foreshadowing of an Unnamed Planet

Ira observes that the map lacks the sky. The children draw an outer ring for it and write a question about an unnamed planet. In this episode the field of vision expands beyond the local river and bridge towards an imagined distant future. The 'unnamed planet' is not yet a concrete extraterrestrial event; it is a question inscribed on the map. Narration connects past and present history with the uncertain time of the future. The gesture marks the novel's larger narrative ambition, not an event in which the characters have already reached another planet.

The Trust Proposal: A New Disguise for Intrusion

At dusk Batuknath's associates arrive in a gleaming car with a proposal to establish a 'People's Memory Trust'. Its entrance just as the map is completed is narratively ironic: a proposal announced in the language of protection and institutional management appears at precisely this moment. First the axe, then the municipal notice; now a file that speaks of service. The opposition shifts from open violence towards the guise of a benevolent guardian. Yet the arrival of a proposal and the lawful establishment of a trust are not identical. Whether the potential appropriation marked out on paper is enacted must be tested against later events.

The Map's Heartbeat and the Chapter's Overall Achievement

The first map of memory is hung between two bamboo posts. It trembles in the wind, as though leaves of the felled tree were rustling again. The scene offers a new, human-made medium for the arboreal body of memory. The chapter's achievement is not merely symbolic: it creates a composite spatial record of names, paths, missing papers and palms. Its limitation is that the difference between the people's map and the government's land records remains unresolved. The emerging trust proposal sharpens the question of public control over the place still further.

Critical Section 158 | Original Chapter 57 — Gaṅgeśa's Question

The Opening of a Historical Embedded Narrative from the People's Map

The proposal that closes Chapter 56 raises the possibility that the people's map of Channa Grove will be brought under external control in the name of a 'trust'. Chapter 57 places Batuknath's red file and Ira's copy of an old manuscript within the same circle of action. The historical episode concerning Gaṅgeśa suddenly enters the village's principal dispute as an embedded narrative. The point of interpreting it is not to apply a Navya-Nyāya method; it is to examine why and how a reference to cultural memory within the narrative changes the voices of its social characters.

The Colour Scheme of the White Car and the Red File

Batuknath himself steps out of a white car, holding a red file. A representative brought the trust proposal in the previous chapter; now its proposer enters Channa Grove in person. White, the outward colour of mourning and respect, and the red file, the forceful material presence of authority and regulations, are set before the communal stump. The authorial narration sees calculation in Batuknath's eyes. This is an assessment by an omniscient narrator, not merely a child's suspicion. The file contains a plan; the actual process of creating the trust has not yet occurred.

The Narrative Manoeuvre of a Trust's Language of Authority

Batuknath fashions a progression of words from feeling to institution, institution to statute, and statute to trust. This ordered verbal sequence constructs a possible story of documentary authority over social memory. Rules, a board of trustees, grants, a research centre and visitor management might all appear beneficial to listeners. But the community's protagonists ask where that authority would come from. The source does not reproduce all the legal clauses of a trust deed. Criticism must neither prove every proposed provision exploitative nor assume that the trust has already been formally constituted.

'Justice' before 'Trust': Ananya's Linguistic Resistance

Ananya places the stone for 'the one whose name has not been found' before Batuknath and asks what justice means before the formation of a trust. The near-homophonous words nyāya (justice) and nyāsa (trust) signify different social arrangements of authority. Batuknath's legal

training equips him for an immediate reply, but the child fixes the question in a human setting. The narratological force lies less in the play on words than in the sequence of the scene: first the nameless stone, then the red file. The author's moral judgment reaches us through the child's voice; nevertheless, the public answer to the proposal remains open.

Ira's Manuscript: The Stage of History within the Story

Ira opens her account with Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the Tattvacintāmaṇi and Mithila's intellectual memory. Within the story this is a representation of a scholar's life based on oral tradition. The narration uses the qualification 'it is said' when introducing accounts of an extraordinary birth and marriage to a woman from a leatherworking caste. That stylistic marker matters greatly: oral tradition is not equivalent to historical verification. Instead of inventing an external history of the controversy, criticism identifies this folktale's narrative work in the novel—its interrogation of caste, memory and honour.

The Story of Birth Five Years Later: The Form of Impossibility

Ira mentions a tradition that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death. Hearing this extraordinary chronology opens a question for the community: can society silence a claim simply by calling it impossible? The source explicitly identifies the account as oral tradition, so the review does not present it as a verified biological event in Gaṅgeśa's historical life. At the level of narrative, the exaggeration exposes unequal social decisions about legitimacy. The character's principal creative function is to reveal the distance between stories 'accepted' and 'excluded' from collective life.

The Account of Marriage to a Leatherworking Woman: An Inconvenient Biography

Ira's account raises the question of Gaṅgeśa's alleged marriage to a woman from a leatherworking caste, unsettling the social memory of the village's elders, young people and families. Meera describes the symbolic suppression of relationships across caste lines and of women's wishes in the name of honour. It would be inappropriate to convert this character's statement into a conclusion verified by historical records. The central event is the disturbance of the village's untroubled image of a 'great man' by a narrative voice of controversy. The embedded story becomes a critique of the limits of contemporary registers of names.

Delimiting a Character's Allegations against Named Critics

Gop names certain scholars and accuses them of concealing inconvenient aspects of Gaṅgeśa's life. This is a disputed statement made by a character in the novel, not a historical conclusion independently verified by

research. A source-faithful reading makes clear that the story turns the allegation into a larger metaphor of 'the murder of memory', but does not independently examine the actual writings, intentions or textual variants associated with the accused scholars. Literature's ethical intensity must remain distinct from verified claims about external literary history.

How the Question of Caste Changes the Collective Audience

On hearing the Gaṅgeśa folktale, villagers who were previously moved by the recitation of the dead now remember their own positions in marriage, hearth, caste, well and lineage. This transformation of the internal audience is significant. In the same public space, the scene disturbs the social group's sense of comfort. More specific questions emerge about the role caste played in the earlier struggles of Munna, Meera, Devika and Ananya for justice to names. The novelist does not leave society as an innocent listener; power structures within communal memory become visible.

Twelve Thousand Lines in the Roots: Scholarship Made Visible

After a character refers to the intellectual scope of Gaṅgeśa's great treatise, the rings of the stump glitter as though they contain 'twelve thousand' lines. In this magical image scholarship is transformed into the tree's annual rings and joined to the village's social memory. But the number is an imagistic utterance: neither a scientific count of the tree's actual growth rings nor a verified word count of the text. The supernatural image gathers the characters' cultural experience; the review does not convert it into a numerical historical fact.

Replacing 'Jurisdiction' with 'Duty of Service'

Aruni crosses out 'jurisdiction of the trust' on the first page of the red file and writes 'duty of service'. This physical act of inscription lies at the centre of the chapter. The crossing-out of a particular expression on a document challenges Batuknath's presumed ownership of the language of his social plan. Yet it does not prove that an official amendment to a trust deed has been completed. It is a dramatic act of the people's counter-writing upon the original file. The verbal alteration declares a condition for future collective arrangements, not a final legal outcome.

Deferring the Proposal: Neither Punishment nor Acceptance

At the close, Batuknath's trust proposal is neither accepted nor rejected; the red file is set aside until people have been heard. This decision exemplifies the novel's recurrent technique of deferring conclusions. The community does not instantly leap into a declaration of unqualified opposition; it keeps open a space to examine the question of authority within the

vocabulary of service. 'Deferral' here has a meaning different from a lawyer's old postponement of dates: it is a pause for the affected people's consent and public scrutiny. The reader still does not know the outcome of the trust's actual formation.

The New Arrival of a Mobile Tribute: Two Parallel Stages

At night an advertisement for a luminous digital tribute platform reaches the villagers' phones. It does not directly name Chandrapal's company but bears the emblem of a new cultural-service organisation. The screen scene immediately after the red file has been deferred is a form of parallel editing in which social control enters through another medium. Batuknath's trust and Chandrapal's app appear as distinct institutional events with similar possible aims; a complete documentary record of a legal alliance between them is not yet available. The reader can perceive the direction of the next chapter's account of a network of exploitation.

The Narrative Limits of the Philosophical Undertone

At the chapter's end a separate, parenthetical undertone refers to a kādambarī, obstacles to a treatise and purported episodes from a life. This is not a necessary scene occurring at the same time as the principal events at Channa Grove; it is an almost appendicial authorial voice linked to the memory of classical learning. Its narrative location should be kept analytically distinct. The chapter's central formal achievement is to question the political vocabulary of the trust through the Gaṅgeśa oral tradition. Its limitation is that the long explanatory embedded narrative briefly interrupts the immediate dramatic tension among the child, Meera and Batuknath.

Critical Section 159 | Original Chapter 58 — The Crocodile in the Memory App

From the Red File to the Blue Screen: The Antagonist's Transformation

In Chapter 57 the red file proposing a 'People's Memory Trust' was put aside, but an advertisement for a digital tribute immediately appeared on the villagers' mobile phones. 'The Crocodile in the Memory App' is the next chapter in this shift of medium. The narrative antagonist of exploitation is no longer a land survey or the authority of a trust, but a digital page asking bereaved families for information. The attractive combination of blue, water, flowers, lamps and the village's name creates a covering of sympathy. Its literary effect is that betrayal initially resembles assistance rather than an act of violent assault.

Extensive Personal Information behind an Attractive Home Page

Devika opens the app. It requests numerous particulars: cause of death, identity documents, bank details, status of compensation, telephone number, a list of family members, photographs and the numbers of relatives. A direct conflict emerges between the social need to record names and the excessive collection of personal data. Devika closes the phone in the text; there is no event in which she submits all the information about her brother. The novelist communicates the scale of possible emotional injury through the sequence of fields on the form. Each box opens another crisis of ownership concerning a victim's memory.

Ananya's Question about the Button to Immortalise a Name

The children place the phone in their midst beside the stump at Channa Grove. One child asks why so much paperwork is necessary to make a name immortal. The question's simplicity becomes a critique of the app's sweeping language of consent. The practical purpose of preserving the dead through personal information may be very different from the possibility of hidden profit. The girl recognises the difference between preserving someone's name and asking for the key to their home in its name. The narrator first presents the screen's appeal as beautiful and then reveals its mechanisms of control; it does not reject every digital medium automatically.

Meera's Conditions of Consent at the Narrative Centre

Reading the app's terms of permission, Meera identifies sweeping uses of family materials for research, sharing, publicity, relief and donations. A

woman who had considered uploading an image of her drowned husband decides against it and puts her phone away. The protection of survivors' rights becomes not a slogan but an actual click held back. The crucial distinction is between the freedom to enter information on an app and consent extracted under pressure in a moment of mourning. Meera's voice gives this difficult ethical tension a concrete human basis, although the text does not supply an independent legal examination of the platform's entire agreement.

Gop's Organisation of Three Layers

Gop identifies three levels: a cultural platform, a service group and the technology of remembrance. His account helps explain the social consequences of institutional opacity within the story. A logical resemblance is drawn between the controlled information of Chandrapal's earlier gambling industry and the collection of data by the new bereavement service. Yet the list of organisations is a character's observation, not independent documentary evidence of each institution's registration, balance sheet or legal ownership. The narrative raises suspicion about an economic network; Bhavesh's later statement clarifies certain operational arrangements.

A Classroom Scene in Ira's Teaching: A Forum for Questions

Recalling the episode concerning Gaṅgeśa, Ira asks the children to distinguish the appearance they have seen on the screen, its inferred purpose and the words actually used. This teaching episode is dialogue between characters within the original novel; it is not a separate philosophical method employed by this critical study. Its narrative purpose is to teach the children to read the actual written words of the screen alongside the wondrous metaphor of a magical crocodile. The instructive voice sometimes interrupts dramatic action, but here it also helps give immediate meaning to the app's particulars.

The Screen's Supernatural Alteration and the Limits of Reality

In Chandrapal's office, the button labelled 'name' turns into 'proof', 'donation' into 'responsibility', and 'acceptance' into 'whose right?' The impossible declaration 'Tattvacintāmaṇi mode' also appears on the screen. The narrator explicitly states that this is not a feature created by a real programmer but a magical effect of the stump's laughter. The boundary is crucial: readers must not take it for a reconstructed history of technological intervention. The scene converts the advertisement's one-way instructions into supernatural counter-questions, although repeated screen miracles risk becoming predictable devices.

The Legitimate Question of Social Reach

A young man asks what is wrong if a digital platform can carry names to distant places. Devika does not prohibit the platform outright; she asks who will control the information. This exchange protects the narrative from one-dimensional opposition to technology. The reach of an app, easier access to assistance and communication with distant communities are potential benefits; commercial appropriation of bereaved persons' data and names is a possible harm. Both positions receive an opportunity to speak through the characters. The narrator does not weaken the conflict by denying possible benefits in advance.

Chandrapal's View of Forms Left Incomplete by Grief

In his distant office Chandrapal studies figures showing how many people opened a page, entered a name or left midway through it. The narrator says that he takes an interest in the possibility of contacting those who abandoned their forms. This depicts the character's exploitative perspective from within; it does not establish that every incomplete form resulted in successful fraud. The story shows the fear that supposedly neutral statistics might become a means of extracting value from emotion. The difference between metrics on a remote screen and the solid stones of Channa Grove becomes another division of ethical perspective.

The Concrete Civic Practice of the School of Names

The children decide not to forbid any family from using the app, but to explain the consequences before a name is given. Three questions—who has the right to give the name, how images of grief will be used, and who owns remembrance—become rules for public education. At this point the story moves from ethical instruction towards a form of social practice that can be examined. The first class actually takes place in the text; it does not follow that all families are permanently safe or that the platform's wider spread has been stopped. Warning and communal autonomy coexist.

An Elderly Woman's Choice between the Screen and the Stone

An elderly woman has been told that entering her son's name in the app might bring government assistance. Devika explains the process; the woman ultimately writes the name on a stone and returns home. This is an important moment of agency because the woman makes the decision herself. She is neither automatically helpless through complete digital illiteracy nor a passive follower of a doctrine devised by the author. The advertisement's claim about assistance is not verified as an actual government scheme. She chooses control over the public circulation of her son's name. The novelist condenses a sensitive effect into a small individual action.

The Trace of Raghav's Future Message on the Glass

An unnamed, vanishing message arrives on Gop's phone: the donation code will change; Raghav is watching. After the message disappears, a faint outline of a leaf remains on the glass. This magical remnant of an erased medium becomes the plot's next knot. The text does not clearly identify the sender; the anonymous source therefore cannot confidently be described as an employee of Raghav. The message foreshadows conspiracy within the narrative; the whole new code used by Raghav has not yet been read.

Preparing the Arena for the Four Crocodiles

At the chapter's close, the government notice, the trust's red file, the memorial app's screen and Raghav's donation code surround the stump as 'four crocodiles'. This is a powerful integrating metaphor, but the four objects have different factual and legal statuses: an actual notice, a proposed trust, an available digital platform and a warning of an impending change in a code. Treating them as events at an identical stage merely because one metaphor names them together would be an analytical error. Narratologically, the encirclement from four directions prepares a multi-medium arena for the coming conflict.

Assessment of the Chapter: The Language of Protection versus the Transfer of Rights

The strongest achievements of 'The Crocodile in the Memory App' are the dramatic reading of a sweeping consent agreement, the elderly woman's refusal and the children's school of names. Its weakness is the recurrence of screen text spontaneously turning into moral counter-words. Nevertheless, the village's communal response is not a blind ban: people receive an opportunity to understand and decide for themselves. The chapter translates the novel's fundamental question of remembrance into a modern scene of data ownership. The next episode about the code will reveal the role of a junior employee working within this struggle for power.

Critical Section 160 | Original Chapter 59 — Raghav Signal's New Code

From a Faint Leaf to a New Reading of the Plot

Chapter 59 turns the residual leaf-shape on Gop's phone glass at the end of Chapter 58 into a new document of mystery. The following morning people sit around the stump to read the code. This construction gives the narrative a rhythm of suspenseful investigation rather than philosophical debate: a half-erased message, secret signs, a statement by a young employee, and a third warning at the end of the night. A folk song speaks of preserving a copy and attaching a timestamp; unlike the supernatural mark on the glass in the prose, the actual completion of this claim is not fully narrated.

The Narrative Failure of Raghav's Command to 'Delete'

Raghav 'Signal' Somani believes that erasing a message in time erases its history. Against this principle of making things invisible, the narrator sets the leaves of the grove, children's memories and marks on glass. The magical object is not equivalent to a technical forensic procedure, but it gives visual form to a refusal of social forgetting. The erased message becomes something that can be remembered and read again. Though its 'sender' is absent in the city, his controlled words become the subject of public reading at the stump.

The Arrangement of Words and Codes for Donations

Saumya shows a list of symbols—brackets, dots, crescents, an inverted lamp and leaf veins—associated with terms such as offerings of lamps, offerings of water, scholarships, a peace fund and assistance. The marks resemble devotional ornament, but acquire possible secret economic meanings within the story. This double reading is an attractive narrative device for constructing a vocabulary of crime. Yet the precise financial routes, amounts and payment schedules behind each mark cannot be fully verified from this scene in the original prose. The list of signs opens a new direction for inquiry.

Meera's Linguistic Defence of Privacy

Gop says Raghav calls money a donation, commission a service, theft a procedure, and deletion privacy. Meera immediately corrects him: privacy is the right of a victim, not a cave in which a criminal can hide. In this intervention the story questions its own ethical vocabulary. Against Gop's generalisation, Meera preserves the legitimate human meaning of the original word. This is an outstanding polyphonic moment: even while

showing an exploiter's abuse of language, literature does not destroy the value of the word being abused.

Bhavesh Enters: The Role of a Junior Insider

Bhavesh, a young man employed on Chandrapal's memorial app, decides to attend the public gathering. He explains that Raghav used to send instructions for arranging the categories of donations on the tribute platform. His account clarifies some practical meanings of signs such as brackets and leaf veins. This is a significant change in the plot: a real employee's spoken voice becomes available, displacing the magical signs on a distant screen. Nevertheless, an independent transcript or signed statement corroborating Bhavesh's words is not immediately presented. This is a narrative scene of a character's admission.

The Contradiction between Not Knowing and Knowing the Advertising

Bhavesh initially says he did not know the work was wrong. When Meera questions him, he admits that he knew grieving relatives uploaded names in the expectation that their sorrow would be protected. The two statements reflect unequal levels of knowledge. It is possible both to lack full understanding of the technical or financial network and to know that grieving families place their trust in it. Even at the dramatic moment of an insider's testimony, the narrator does not erase the junior employee's responsibility beneath the orders of an unseen exploiter. Equally, he should not be treated as the proprietor of the entire conspiracy.

The Contradictory Weight of Raghav's Absence

Raghav himself is not at the stump. The supposition that he occupies a glass room in a distant city is introduced through the narrator's qualified wording. His codes, instructions and hidden meanings have a stronger effect than bodily presence at the gathering would have had. This is a particular narrative technique for a modern economic antagonist: though physically absent from the scene, a character is present through verbal and digital traces. Criticism must not, however, transform a 'perhaps' into a fact of definite live surveillance from afar. The scene draws on the narrator's uncertainty and the knowledge available from the characters' circumstances.

Batuknath's Double Voice of Legal Caution

Batuknath warns that it may be difficult to secure the admissibility of digital information in court. His previous tendency towards professional self-protection within the fictional world may lead readers to distrust the warning. Yet procedures for testing digital evidence can indeed be difficult,

and that general possibility does not make every statement by this character false. Ananya's response demands that people be heard first; it does not prove that legal scrutiny has been rendered pointless. The narrative preserves a discursive tension between social need and institutional procedure.

From the Language of Religious Donation to a Second Immersion of the Body

Aruni says that when the word 'donation' becomes a code for crime, a dead person's name sinks into another water burial. The sentence extends the novel's titular metaphor into the economics of digital platforms. Earlier the waters beneath the bridge swallowed bodies; now a public display offered in their honour may seek ownership of people's identities. Yet the figurative resemblance must not erase the distinct kinds of harm involved in actual killing, the covert collection of data and the business of donations. The metaphor's force comes from connecting separate experiences, not declaring them identical.

Kabaddi's Open Boundary versus the Closed Code

The children form a circle for play. In contrast to the closed group that uses secret codes, kabaddi's voices are public, its breathing audible to everyone and its boundaries visible beneath the feet. The reworking of the language of play is particularly exact because the ghosts' kabaddi at the beginning of the novel was a cultural instrument of resistance. Here play itself becomes a democratic metaphor for the structure of information. Where a code seeks private control, the game calls for names to be pronounced collectively. But saying that the code has been 'broken' in the game and tracing the full technical route through financial accounts are two different events.

Bringing the Leatherworker's Name inside the Circle

Late in the chapter an elderly leatherworker steps forward and says his name too must have an equal place in justice. The children mark his name inside the circle rather than at its outer edge. The question raised by the embedded account of Gaṅgeśa and caste enters the immediate action of a new character. The significance of this scene is a change in a particular person's public place, not an exercise in classical terminology. Still, writing one elder's name within the circle does not end caste exclusion throughout the village. The narrative depicts a new symbolic act of local participation.

'Remove the Source': The Threatening Incompleteness of a Message

At night a warning appears as a blue mark on the kabaddi line: 'Where there is listening, there is risk; remove the source.' The people look at

Satyavrat, but he does not rise; he places his pen beside the children's register. Does 'source' signify an attack on a particular individual, or an instruction to destroy the collective practice of listening? Ananya chooses the second meaning: the source is the community's ears. The message's real sender, the organisation of any physical threat and the next event remain uncertain. In place of paralysing fear, the story develops communal organisation.

The Limits of the Breaking of the Magical Blue Line

As Ananya writes 'Source of silence: collective ears', the blue line in the earth splits and turns to dust. The elderly ghost signals that the code will be read upon the story's screen. This supernatural moment of triumph expresses the listening community's resolve, not the actual complete dismantling of the financial network, mule accounts or routes taken by donation money. The novelist foreshadows another reading of Satyavrat's second silence on the next day, so the victory over the code does not become an immediate final conclusion. 'Listen, then write' recurs as the rule for subsequent action.

The Chapter's Overall Formal Position

In 'Raghav Signal's New Code', the leaf left by vanished words, the signs for donations, Bhavesh's hesitant admission, the leatherworker's public demand and the blue line on the ground generate different levels of tension. Its distinctive achievement is the entrance of Bhavesh as a concrete character occupying an intermediary position within the network. Its risk is that supernatural letters appearing on screens may pronounce an immediate moral verdict and narrow the reader's uncertainty. The next problem—Satyavrat's second silence—poses harder practical questions after this dramatic visual resolution: when should a listener speak, when remain silent and to whom should the authority to decide belong?

Critical Section 161 | Original Chapter 60 — Satyavrat Mehta's Second Silence

Establishing a Second Silence in Opposition to the First

In Chapter 49, the ledger of silence rendered Satyavrat's earlier reticence a fault of social neglect. Chapter 60 gives the same action a new meaning. On hearing about Raghav's donation code, people demand an immediate lawsuit, public protest or order from Satyavrat; he does not spring up as an instant hero. From this pause a second silence is born: rather than covering the community's voices with his own, he makes room for them. The narrator reverses the meaning of an ethical term according to circumstance. Whose silence, before whom, at what moment and in relation to what power are now the central questions.

A Place of Waiting beside the Dried-Up Pond

Satyavrat sits beside a dried-up pond on the edge of the village. In contrast to the lively public gathering at the grove, this deserted place forms an interval in the character's self-revision. He draws lines in the mud: earlier the children made a map, while here the lines are a modest exercise in self-examination. Ananya comes with the register and extends a collective invitation. This setting has the pace of one person's slow response, removed from distant administrative authority. Amid the active conflict, the narrative briefly slows the rhythm of its prose.

Ananya's Question: Listener First, or Lawyer?

Ananya wants Satyavrat's capacity for understanding, but does not want him installed as the principal person who pronounces decisions. Satyavrat acknowledges that in his first silence he suppressed others' voices; in the second he must restrain his own hasty answers. Ananya's question, 'First a listener, then a lawyer?', condenses the change in his life's direction. This ethical humility is commendable, but not evidence that enduring justice has been secured. A time for proper institutional intervention may yet arrive. If permanent silence obstructs assistance to the injured, it too will become a new problem.

Four Papers, Four Different Claims

Around the stump lie the municipality's yellow notice, Batuknath's proposed trust deed, a printed copy of Chandrapal's digital platform and a paper bearing Raghav's donation code, all held down by stones. The novelist brings the four crocodiles into a single scene. Their metaphorical resemblance suggests possibilities of exploitation, but the documents have distinct factual statuses: an issued notice, a proposed institution, a

functioning platform and a paper setting out a secret code. By arranging these unequal objects within one circle, the story depicts a struggle over social rights on many fronts. Analytical criticism must not call all four fully proved crimes merely because they provoke the same ethical warning.

At the Centre, the Stone for 'The One Whose Name Has Not Been Found'

Satyavrat sits outside the gathering while Ananya places the stone for an unnamed person in the middle. Through this spatial arrangement, the scene establishes whose voice the community will regard as paramount. The official of the state is not on the hero's platform: the absence of the unidentified victim occupies its centre. The novel's recurring symbol of the 'unnamed' becomes an operative code of conduct. Yet the moral centrality of a stone is not an event in which a court or municipality formally recognises title to the site.

The Independence of Devika's Voice

Devika questions the commercial uses of photographs bearing names, the weeping of families and donation buttons. Here a grieving sister is herself a critic of the project's vocabulary; Satyavrat does not speak in her place. This arrangement of agency weakens the possibility of a solitary hero rescuing the people through the actions of a 'man of law'. Devika analyses possible injuries. The text does not narrate a comprehensive factual situation in which every registered photograph or every donation has already been stolen. Her voice attempts to make prevention a collective responsibility.

Meera's Language of Privacy and Saumya's Comparative Reading of Four Vocabularies

Meera calls the making of an image of mourning without permission a renewed humiliation. Saumya reads the terms used in the four documents: vacant land, heritage, digital tribute and revival. Language becomes a principal field of social ownership within this list. Different institutions use different words, yet none directly specifies who has the right to guard the names. The novelist creates a kind of documentary collage. Women become active readers of language who drive the central event; they are not confined to the role of symbols of mourning.

Ba's Recollection of Gaṅgeśa: An Inconvenient Life against an Idol

Ba repeats the account of Gaṅgeśa's alleged cross-caste marriage and the selective editing of memory, suggesting that erasing the inconveniences of a lived life in order to turn a great person into an idol may be a profound form of violence. Here oral tradition functions as a moral comparison within the narrative, not as an externally verified historical conclusion. Its

thematic work is clear: converting the names of the dead into decorative tourist attractions can remove the social pain attached to them. Reusing the folktale connects the immediate dispute to an intellectual inheritance, although it also slows the scene's dramatic movement somewhat.

The Reversed Sequence of the Proposer's Oath

Satyavrat says that whoever would build a memorial must first visit the homes of the dead, whoever offers digital support must first put the mobile phone away and hear their names, and whoever asks for donations must first show the accounts. The community prepares a page entitled 'The Proposer's Oath before the Names'. This is the chapter's most concrete outcome. In place of the formal authority of a proposer, it begins an order of responsibility to the injured. But the collective oath is not an administratively approved, legally binding contract. How the proposers' conduct changes remains to be examined.

The Delayed Signature and the First Marks of Children's Hands

Satyavrat steps back from the position of signing the paper first. The children place symbols of vigilance—a fish, a leaf, a glass marble and an open eye—before Satyavrat's name is added. The scene precisely shapes a political and communal statement: authority's grip loosens and children become the first co-authors. These marks do not automatically satisfy every legal formality required of signatures; the narrative changes the ethical order of participation.

The Limited Decision to Stop a Live Broadcast

A publicity worker associated with Chandrapal arrives with a phone and proposes a live broadcast of the gathering. Devika covers the screen and says, 'Not today; the camera can come later.' This is a new decision based on consent at a particular time. It is not a declaration that the gathering will remain secret forever: a family's first breath takes precedence over a public platform's claim to it. The novelist avoids making available technology an absolute enemy. The scene is particularly concrete because a woman stops a camera; the screen does not go dark through a miracle but through human action.

Announcing the First Festival of Names

The assembly decides to hold a festival of names on the following day—without music, a stage or garlands. Each household is to bring a name, a sign, a memory and a question; there is also a proposal to read the living names of wrongdoers as calls for accountability rather than celebratory acclamation. The decision to hold the event occurs in this chapter; the festival itself does not. The distinction between foreshadowing and

completed action must remain explicit. Aruni, Ananya, Meera, Devika, Saumya, Ira and Gop, by preparing the page together, form a social grammar for the coming gathering.

The Pause of Silence and the Need for Action

Satyavrat's thoughts on the difference between his two silences are a character's inward self-examination. The former man had the capacity to issue immediate orders; the new listener hears the people's voices before responding. Yet continuous inactivity is not a solution either. At the ceremony in the next chapter, characters rise to help an elderly woman who faints. Read alongside this foreshadowing, the second silence appears not as passive muteness but as restraint suited to circumstances. The narrator does not replace the wrongdoing of the first silence with the sanctity of endless silence; action at the right moment remains a test.

The Section's Overall Dramatic Contribution

The new events in 'Satyavrat Mehta's Second Silence' lie in the four written documents, the collective oath, the order of signatures and the decision to stop the camera. The character's internal dialogue comes alive through its connection with these concrete actions. A limitation is that the rules of public education often emerge like almost finished manifestos, potentially reducing the space for a reader's multiple interpretations. The conclusion nevertheless remains open: neither have the proposers accepted the oath nor has the grove been declared permanently secure. What has been achieved is the uncertain preparation for the next day's festival of names.

Critical Section 162 | Original Chapter 61 — The First Festival of Names

The Discomfort of the Word "Festival" Amid Mourning

In Channa Gachhi, the first Festival of Names begins without drums, flags, a platform, or formal invitations. For Ananya, repeating a name is not merely an act of weeping but an affirmation of social presence. Under this definition, a festival is not a contest of jubilation; it is a social rite that makes room for an absent human being. Some villagers are initially startled by the word, but agreement emerges through questions and counterquestions. The narrator breaks the emotional uniformity of mourning to explore different public forms of collective grief.

Seating Arrangements in the Four Directions

Children sit to the east, families to the west, elders to the north, and, to the south, those who cannot stay away despite declaring themselves free of blame. This arrangement makes social roles visible. Satyavrat sits at the back on a broken brick and refuses a privileged seat. Although the scene resembles an open circle, the positions occupied by its participants carry different meanings. The narrative constructs an indirect moral theatre; the divisions of seating do not, however, establish an equality that has erased every distinction in actual society. Nor is the evidentiary basis for the southern participants' culpability uniform: their self-awareness is what matters here.

The Possibility of Disagreement over the First Name

Whose name should be spoken first: a labourer drowned at the bridge, a young man killed in a digital fraud, or a woman caught in silence? A minor dispute arises. A child proposes beginning with "the one whose name could not be found." The decision reveals that an orderly sequence of recitation is not automatically impartial. First place in time confers recognition and visibility. When the unnamed stone is raised, the answer is not an individual reply from a family but the children's collective "Present." Giving the unnamed first place makes the lacuna in social memory a matter of public concern.

"Sar…": Verbal Respect for an Incomplete Name

The second stone bears only "Sar…". An elderly woman considers several possible names, but Meera prevents anyone from inventing a complete one. This is a rare and exceptionally effective moment of fidelity to sources in the novel. Faced with the emotional temptation of completion and the obligation to respect incompleteness, Ananya reads the fragment as it

stands. Expanding "Sar…" into Sarayu, Saroj, or another definite name could perpetrate a fresh violence of misidentification. Such textual restraint is also critically important in the context of the earlier inconsistency between Sarayu Devi and Sarayu Mahato.

The Social Rebirth of the Meaning of "Present"

"Present" becomes a popular response set against the court's opposition of "present" and "absent." The body is gone, yet social grief and unanswered questions remain present. This speech act draws the inert name on a stone into the community's living relationships. Nevertheless, saying "Present" does not literally restore the dead to life: the community acknowledges their absence even as it creates a just form of remembrance. The children's answer for an unknown person does not resolve an unjust disappearance; it refuses to let that disappearance be publicly obscured.

Neither Ask about Caste nor Conceal It

People voluntarily add lineage, occupation, neighbourhood, river, or mother's name to the names being read. Some wish to state their caste; others do not. After the episode concerning Gaṅgeśa's popular legend, caste at the Festival of Names becomes not simply an identifying attribute but a possible testimony to humiliation. The formal contribution of the scene lies in opening multiple choices of identification. The narrative privileges each person's voluntary utterance rather than surrendering the entire regulation of a communal register of names to a single abstract rule. It recognises both the right to speak of historical caste oppression and the independent right to personal privacy.

Devika and the Two Voices of the Maternal Response

Devika trembles while speaking Ujjwal Jha's name; her mother responds "Present"; Devika then says that his silence, too, is present. In this brief exchange, sister, mother, and the dead man's invisible fear constitute three distinct registers of voice. Devika's earlier educational activism has not entirely freed her from private grief. The author does not define a character's strength as the capacity never to tremble. The variation between "Ujjwal Jha" and the earlier "Ujjwal Kumar Jha," as well as the previous inconsistency in the account of his death, must remain on the critical record.

A New Meaning of Presence for Meera, Who Is Alive

Meera initially says that she is alive and does not wish her name to be read at a festival for the dead. The women urge her to agree, but the final utterance comes from her own mouth: her right to privacy is present. The scene proposes a new principle under which respect for a living survivor

equals remembrance of the dead. Yet the ethical distance between communal pressure and voluntary choice must remain marked. The narrative gives her an explicit final statement; that does not mean the fundamental question of consent has been completely settled.

Room for "Each Name" on Gop's List

Gop brings a list covering many categories of victims. The children ask not merely for a list but to hear each name separately. This slowing of textual pace is a significant literary transformation. Statistical density diminishes while the time allowed to an individual voice expands. Gop's familiar work of collecting records now encounters its own limits on the assembly platform. The text, however, specifies neither the total number of names in the ritual nor the full history of every registered person. An extension of listening time matters more than event density.

A Kabaddi Breath after Ten Names

After every ten names the children play kabaddi in a circle. When breath runs out, it means not defeat but the next watch over a name. This rule transforms the game's older aggressive opposition of victory and loss into the work of safeguarding memory. The recurring game also offers a bodily pause during a long recitation. Respecting physical limits—refusing to punish a tired child—is an important sign of the chapter's social sensitivity. The regular rhythm of ten nevertheless remains a ritual device, not a detailed account of an actual system of social protection.

The Circular Line Extending across Pond, Bridge and Sky

During kabaddi, a line of sunlight seems to extend from the stump to the pond, the bridge piers, and the sky. Far away, a corresponding circle appears on Raghav's screen. The scene anticipates a future geographical expansion beyond the boundaries of a village game. The earlier cartographic question of the "unnamed planet" also casts its shadow here, but the characters have not embarked on a journey beyond the sky. The apparently magical expansion of vision and the opposing party's screen effect are presented in parallel narrative editing.

Deferring the Trust's Invitation: The Community's Own Time

Batuknath's assistant wishes to read an invitation to preliminary consultations on establishing a trust at the assembly centre. Ananya stops him; Aruni says that today belongs to the dead and that discussion of trusts and schemes can wait until tomorrow. This is an extraordinary decision: the people's assembly claims authority over its own time. The proposer's words are denied immediate access to the public platform. The assembly does not permanently reject legal deliberation; it determines the priority

of listening in the present. It protects the community's own ritual time while leaving the coming conflict with official institutions unresolved.

Supporting the Fainting Widow: A Test of Silence

An elderly labourer's widow faints as soon as a name is read. Satyavrat does not remain seated in silence; he runs to support her. His direct action clarifies the intrinsic limit of the "second silence." Someone who keeps silent to make room for another's voice must nevertheless offer physical assistance when needed. This is a concrete test of the character's ethical education—not mute idealism but an embodied response. Yet helping one widow does not establish that a complete social safety net has come into being.

The Festival's End and the Uncertain Premonition of a Bud

After dusk the circle of stones grows; the children's fingers are stained with blue ink and the women's throats grow tired. The yellow notice and the white trust document remain behind, unable to close the new struggle over the meanings of mourning. Satyavrat glimpses green in a fissure of the stump but does not touch it. Is it a trick of moonlight or a bud? The answer must await morning. This formal restraint is effective: amid the regular marvels of magical realism, a character does not instantly assign certainty to what he sees. The next chapter will open a many-voiced visual verification of the new bud.

Critical Section 163 | Original Chapter 62 — The Green Point

The Delicate Morning After the Night of the Festival of Names

At the end of Chapter 61, Satyavrat catches a green glimmer in a fissure of the stump, but does not immediately decide whether it is an illusion or a bud. Chapter 62 allows that point to be seen clearly, though still minutely, through Ananya's eyes at dawn. Here the narrator gradually converts the preceding night's symbol of hope into a visible event the following morning. The green point is so tiny that it might disappear as soon as one looks away; nevertheless, it becomes the next focus of the vigil over names. This time the novel's expansive magical world comes to rest upon a minute, living point of plant growth.

The Child's Ethical Rule Against Touching

On seeing the bud, Ananya does not touch it; she first bends down and attempts to listen. The earlier rule of listening before picking up objects from the stump is now applied to a living shoot. At this moment, "protection" means neither possession nor the desire to pluck something for inspection, but allowing another living being the space to develop independently. Ananya is the questioner in almost every episode, yet here bodily restraint matters more than questioning. The faint kabaddi-breath that can be heard belongs to the narrative world's supernatural events; it is not an account of actual plant physiology.

Unequal Interpretations of the Bud: A Father's Reply or a Biological Shoot

The children call the bud a miracle, the tree's rebirth, or a father's answer from beyond death. A schoolteacher explains the botanical possibility of a shoot emerging from a dormant bud. The author places these interpretations together in a shared public scene. The emotional significance of popular belief and the natural explanation offered by biology do not necessarily cancel each other out, although their factual claims differ. Ananya's rule is to hear every interpretation first and then look. In this way, the narrative sustains the possibility of multiple readings characteristic of magical realism.

The Parallel Between the Tree's Severed Body and the Surviving Name

Seeing the green point, Ba draws a connection between the sap surviving the tree's cutting and names surviving in society's wounded memory. This

metaphor offers a small, visible answer to Chapter 52's proposal, "New Trees, Old Names." Yet the actual botanical activity of sap and the social agency of memory are not entirely equivalent. Rather than simply asserting an impossible resurrection, the narrator reveals a new temporal possibility for an injured tree. The entry "green point after the names" in the register directly records a sequence in time; it does not conclusively establish a supernatural cause.

The Theft of the Bud's Image by the Tribute App

On Chandrapal's app, a photograph of the bud is promoted under the title "Rebirth," accompanied by a conspicuous donation button. This incident extends the earlier crisis of collecting private names, family photographs, and tears as data to the image of a plant. The danger now concerns not merely photographs of the dead but the conversion of a community's living site into branded material. The photograph has already reached many places—the text explicitly records its circulation—but does not specify either the total financial proceeds or any final legal ownership of the bud. Devika's resistance constitutes an attempt to prevent such prospective commercial control.

The Limits of Meera's Right to Determine What May Be Seen

Meera insists that the stories and images of people and families who have suffered injury must not be displayed without permission. Around the bud there arises not merely a physical bamboo enclosure but a code governing spectatorship: listen to the recitation of names, explain why photographs are being taken, and collectively resolve to prohibit their sale. This is a new rule of social conduct, not a copyright regime recognised in law or a complete cessation of public transmission. The narrator extends the discussion of the boundaries of the private body to a community's rights over images of its local environment.

The Photograph Already in Circulation and the Unequal Power of the Vigil

Some young people state plainly that, in the digital age, it is difficult to stop a photograph once it has escaped into circulation. Devika argues that this makes rules all the more necessary. Through their disagreement, the novel depicts a genuine conflict over the limits of power rather than offering an easy, popular prohibition. A local vigil and the global circulation of images are not instruments of equal magnitude. An ethical resolution does not confer omnipotent control over an ongoing flow. The plot's credibility depends on acknowledging that greater human vigilance cannot itself erase an image already disseminated.

The Old Ghost's New Kabaddi

The old ghost appears distinctly beside the bud and announces that the game is now about protecting the shoot. The kabaddi boundary is no longer a fixed circle on the earth but an invisible limit around the tiny leaf. Whoever enters must utter a name; on coming out, the player must say, "Present." Losing one's breath does not mean defeat but the beginning of another act of listening. The ghost's ancient game has again been transformed into a protective social practice. The change begins with the command of a supernatural teacher and gains the possibility of endurance through the children's daily actions.

Water, Not Punishment, When Breath Gives Out

Watching the new rules of kabaddi, Satyavrat compares them with his experiences of courtroom time, adjournments, and the humiliation of victims. A principle takes shape in his mind: when someone runs out of breath, give that person water rather than punishment. This thought belongs to the character's ethical understanding of life; it is not the actual drafting of a complete judicial code. The narrative's strength lies in respecting the body's limits within a village game. When a tired child sits in the second row, the game becomes a rhythm of sustained participation rather than an exercise in defeating others.

The Names of Texts in the Cadence of Play

The pupils utter episodes associated with Gangesha, the name of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, and classical terms in the breath-rhythm of kabaddi. Through this narrative device, a book-centred intellectual tradition is brought onto a public stage by means of rhythm, play, and children's bodies. Critical study of the scene should remain attentive to the characters' linguistic performance, cultural quotation, and the rewriting of embedded narratives. Reciting classical terms is not in itself evidence of full methodological training; nor is the oral tradition concerning Gangesha's life as narrated in the novel a historically verified external biography. The principal event is the social circulation of knowledge recited through play.

The Time of Growth from Green Point to Slender Leaf

In the latter part of the chapter, the tiny point becomes a slender leaf. Its colouring weaves together images of the blackened body, red cloth, the blue of water, and the radiance of dew. This metaphor carries the wounded history of the felled tree into a new body. The leaf is also a concrete event in an ordinary process of reproduction and life, upon which a many-coloured poetry of memory is superimposed. The patience required for

growth conveys an experience of biological time. Even if a symbolic rebirth is proclaimed, the tree has not yet been fully restored.

The Emerging Language of Heritage Among Outside Inspectors

Officials, photographers, and consultants arrive from the district to see the bud. Expressions such as "folk culture," "cultural circuit," "interpretation centre," and "tickets" come readily to their lips, but listening to the local recitation of names does not come first. Ananya's question exposes the visitors' priorities. The representatives of the state are not thereby automatically established as wholly culpable; their initial gaze perceives the "potential" for a tourism project. The order of participation—inspection first, involvement afterward—is the episode's central indication of power.

The Appearance of the Heritage-Corridor Document

At night a glossy sheet appears beside the bud, bearing the title "Garh Narikel Heritage Corridor: Preliminary Concept." It gives written form to the possibility of a tourism scheme previously mentioned by the inspectors. Yet the words "Preliminary Concept" themselves indicate that the project has not reached a fully developed construction stage. For criticism, the distance between an uncertain proposal and regulatory authorisation is essential. The magical image of the bud trembling in the paper's shadow turns into an image of the aggressive possibility of institutional control over a new shoot of life.

The Green Point's Multiple Meanings

In Chapter 62, the bud is at once natural botanical growth, a living hope for the remembrance of the dead, an appealing image for digital commerce, and a potential emblem of a government heritage scheme. Amid these different meanings, its actual smallness matters. Readers should not reduce the point either to the unquestionable truth of a complete miracle or merely to the symbol of a project campaign. The characters' different perspectives contend over this fragile site. The chapter's formal strength is its concentration of numerous social forces upon a small object; its weakness is the repeated intervention that explicitly explains the meanings to the reader in a didactic manner.

Critical Section 164 | Original Chapter 63 — The Garh Narikel Heritage Project

The Third Day as Public Time

On the third day after the green point appeared, government vehicles, cultural officers, a municipal clerk, a photographer and a consultant arrive in the village. This precise indication of time turns the tentative interest in a project in Chapter 62 into an actual site visit. The people's names had previously gone unheard, but the felled shade, the crowd and the increasingly visible shoot now attract administrative attention. The narrator creates an ironic reversal in time: after a prolonged silence surrounding human suffering comes the rapid recognition of 'heritage'. Yet the characters' critical perception of 'greed' and the actual personal motives of each official remain separate questions.

The Consultant's Dark Glasses and Self-Reflection

The consultant's glasses seem to reflect not the village but his own face. This visual metaphor opens the chapter by asking what an outsider arriving with a project is capable of seeing. The stones, children and stump of local life become, in his gaze, visitor numbers, physical space and opportunities for development. The narrator does not supply a complete biography of the man; the shine of an accessory invites an inference about his inward disposition. The image draws its strength from a restricted point of view. The colour of the glasses, by itself, is not direct proof of any particular financial offence.

From Stones Bearing Names to Numerical 'Visitors'

Rather than read the individual names inscribed on the stones, the officials count stones, families and people in the crowd. Through this action the earlier register of names risks becoming a set of measurable tourist units. The community, too, had counted names, but its emphasis fell upon the singular grief attached to each stone. An official's initial count could also be part of legitimate resource planning. The satire concerns the sequence —'numbers first, names afterwards'. The narrative places two different purposes of counting before the reader.

Ananya's Question: 'Did You Read the Names?'

Ananya asks the consultant whether he has actually read the names on the stones. He evades the question by saying that they should first be allowed to prepare a plan. The timing of participation is central to this exchange. Will public consent become a retrospective formality attached to an already completed plan, or will those affected take part in determining its

meaning from the beginning? The girl's question makes an ethical claim to agency; it does not establish that every conceivable project is impossible. As in the earlier stories surrounding Gangesha, a complex narrative of responsibility is compressed here into the small word 'first'.

Batuknath's Indirect, Shadow-Like Role

Batuknath is not physically present among the visiting officials, but his earlier draft for a trust is said to have circulated through government files. A young legal adviser also appears at the site. Thus a character absent in person nevertheless participates in the event through institutional paperwork. The technique parallels Raghav's ability to act from a distance through codes. Yet the arrival of a draft in a file is not the same as official approval of Batuknath's entire project. It signals the spread of influence locally, not a document establishing final legal authority.

Four Elements of the Colourful Project Map

The officials display a colourful proposal incorporating a 'Channa Memorial Gate', a 'Ghost-Kabaddi Theatre', a 'Water-Burial Experience Gallery' and a 'Digital Wall of Names'. A tourist route, tickets, sound-and-light displays and an interpretation centre are presented as plans. This narrative image exposes the danger of transforming the ghostly kabaddi of the novel's opening into packaged entertainment. But the original text depicts a printed design, not a completed construction; ghost-kabaddi has not yet become an actual ticketed attraction. The distinction between living experience in the present and its proposed future display is indispensable.

Devika and the Representation of a Mother's Trembling Voice

Devika asks whether an actor will reproduce the trembling voice of a dead person's mother reading a name, and whether the image of a labourer whose body was never recovered will be used to decorate a ticket. This raises a serious theatrical question about representation: who has the right to perform another person's suffering? A cultural project might enable sensitive expressions of public memory, but without the consent of those injured and respect for the dignity of their lives, performance risks becoming exploitation. Devika's objection rests upon the irreplaceable human voice of an individual body; it is not an unconsidered, permanent prohibition of all artistic re-creation.

Meera Extends the Principle of Consent to the Site

Drawing upon experiences of cameras, blackmail and the humiliation of the private body, Meera demands the permission of affected individuals before their stories are staged publicly. The principle of app consent from

Chapter 58 is thus applied anew to the government's heritage proposal. The medium has changed—from an online form to a sound-and-light performance—but the underlying question of control remains. Consent is not a decorative tick on a form; it is a prior condition of the social relationship. The chapter does not, however, separately report the decisions of every family concerning the representation of a dead person's photograph or voice.

Ba's 'First You Cut the Roots': Development's Self-Contradiction

Ba cannot find on the colourful map the first reading of Sarayu's name, the labour lost in the water or the children's night watch. Her bitter observation is that those who cut the roots now plan to sell the shade. The formal force of this statement lies in its immediate joining of the actual cutting of a tree to a proposal for cultural ownership. The text does not, however, establish that every member of the present team personally ordered the earlier felling. The satire addresses institutional continuity, not the determination of each individual's criminal liability.

An Attempt to Sell the Image of Two New Leaves

By the third day, the green point has grown into two leaves. The consultant is eager to photograph them as a symbol of rebirth for the project; Ananya steps between them, granting the shoot a dignity akin to that of a living child. The scene extends the metaphor of privacy into the botanical world. The difference between a photograph, a brand and the value of a living leaf becomes unmistakable. What occurs is an attempt to stop the taking of an image before it happens. No official project logo or completed transfer of rights has yet been established.

Kabaddi Heard in Daylight: Performance versus Living Folklore

The officials hear invisible sounds of kabaddi in daylight and take them for a rehearsal. Aruni replies that the game is older than their plan. In this brief dialogue, the novel turns a critical gaze upon its own central metaphor. Within the living fictional world, ghost-kabaddi is an ancient contact with spirits; on the government's colourful map, it becomes a tourist stage. The times, agents and audiences of these two 'performances' differ. The narrator protects the autonomy of the ghosts' game while also showing the administrative interpretation of an uncanny sound.

'The Name Belongs to Its Bearer; the Vigil Is Collective'

After the officials leave, the children ask who owns each name. The families answer: the name is one's own; keeping watch over it is a collective responsibility. This is one of the most concentrated formulations produced by the novel's extended ethical experiment. 'One's own' marks the personal

and familial claim to identity; ‘collective vigilance’ describes the shared duty to resist erasure. In this duality, communal memory differs from the exclusive authority claimed by an institutional trust. The eventual legal form of public property, memorial management and heritage protection nevertheless remains unresolved.

A New Notice at Midnight: From Proposal to Tender

At midnight a person connected with the municipality arrives carrying a ladder and paste, plants a post near the stump and affixes a white notice. Its heading invites tenders for the construction and presentation of the heritage project. This is the chapter's concrete turn in the plot: the earlier ‘preliminary concept’ enters the stage of a written invitation to tender. The posting of a notice does not mean that a contract has been awarded, construction begun, land transferred or the final procedure for objections concluded. The smell of fresh paper, the secrecy of night and the image of the stump's leaves remaining still generate suspense around the approaching conflict.

Final Assessment: Greed within the Light

The shining official vehicles, photographer, dark glasses, counting of stones, colourful heritage corridor, question of who owns names and midnight tender notice form the narrative arc of Chapter 63. A folk song at the end repeats the warning in a rhythmic refrain; the song's declaration must remain distinct from the actual posting of a notice in the preceding prose. The artistic achievement is the gradual increase in the administrative reality of the plan. Its limitation is that the officials largely constitute a single symbolic group associated with ‘greed’, with few developed differences between their individual voices. The novel does not conclude the conflict; it brings it to the beginning of a formally public phase.

Inter-Sectional Conclusion: Part I, Chapters 56–63

The struggle over place develops through four successive media across Chapters 56–63. First, children create a counter-map of public memory on land the municipality has described as ‘vacant’. Batuknath's red file for a ‘People's Memory Trust’ then introduces the problem of documentary control in the name of protection. Chandrapal's memorial app and Raghav's donation code open the possibility of a digital market in the ownership of memory. Finally, as the green shoot attracts growing public attention, the government's proposed ‘heritage project’ takes the form of a tender. Across this arc, a seemingly simple ritual of mourning beside stones bearing names expands into a multilingual conflict over land,

documents, images, family consent, employees' testimony and public planning.

The first chapter's counter-map—with its red stump, trembling line of the Kamla–Balan, the path taken by Ba's mother, the gap left by a missing receipt and the distinct palms of different families—constructs a fine-grained local history of place. This people's map is not a complete technical equivalent of the state's survey records. Its strength is that it inserts questions about persons, routes and lived experience into administrative blanks. Where a name cannot be recovered, the mark remains 'awaiting identification'. For source-faithful criticism, respect for this negative space is a methodological example: where the novel leaves a place open, the critic must not invent a definite event.

From Chapter 57 onward, the Gangesha material enters the narrative in several forms. Ira, Ba, Meera, Gop and the children evoke it through differing oral traditions, purported biographies, memories of books and language marked by caste-related discomfort. The present criticism does not undertake an independent, multi-source historical verification of Gangesha's life or apply Navya-Nyaya logic as a separate methodology. Its reading is strictly narratological: why does an inset story enter the central struggle over land, which character claims the right to tell it, what distinguishes 'it is said' from historical certainty, and how does the assembly change when living characters speak? Allegations made by characters about real literary scholars are not repeated as established facts. The parenthetical philosophical resonances at the ends of various chapters are likewise treated as a distinct narrative level—an external frame or authorial afterword-like voice—not as direct events of the principal prose narrative.

The memorial-app sequence represents exploitation through more than the frightening glow of a screen. Devika closing a form, Meera articulating the language of consent, an elderly woman choosing her son's name for a stone and Bhavesh's unstable admission of his own part are specific acts of agency by characters positioned unequally within structures of power. The supernatural appearance of 'whose right?' on a screen is one instrument of magical opposition, not final evidence of institutional data ownership. Bhavesh's account of his work in the story of Raghav's code introduces new, concrete source material, but must be read within the limits of a character's statement rather than an independent technical audit. Opening a platform, leaving a form unfinished or deleting a message does not by itself reconstruct the complete financial route by which profits were made.

Satyavrat's second silence marks a major development of character. The earlier silence arose from rank, distance and failure to intervene in time;

here he refrains from covering the collective voice of witnesses with his own words. His response is tested when he helps an elderly woman who faints in Chapter 61. The second silence is therefore not self-protective passivity but a conscious allocation of time for listening. The first public reading of a stone marked 'whose name has not been found', Meera's insistence that the incomplete 'Sar…' must not be invented, the living Meera's right to privacy and the bodily pauses for kabaddi after every ten names make the festival of names a powerful collective practice.

The green point receives a sequential botanical time: a nocturnal doubt in Chapter 61, a tiny actual shoot in Chapter 62 and two leaves in Chapter 63. Children read it as an answer from the dead; a teacher offers the natural explanation of a dormant bud; Ba sees a rebirth of public memory; the app sees a brand image; and the state sees a symbol for tourism. This plurality of readings makes the little leaf a centre of conflict over meaning. Yet the life of a natural shoot is not equivalent to the permanent victory of collective memory. The ecological damage from the earlier felling remains, and the new leaf and the danger of the project are present together.

In Chapter 63 the heritage plan ceases to be merely a character's suspicion. The officials' inspection, the colourful design and, finally, the paper headed 'Invitation to Tender for Construction and Presentation', posted by a municipally connected person, constitute an observable sequence. This is a new institutional stage, but the issue of a tender does not establish that a contract has been approved, construction started or people's rights to land extinguished. The actual scope of an administrative proposal must be distinguished from essayistic condemnation. The novel offers the community the principle 'the name belongs to its bearer; the vigil is collective', but the legal and institutional application of that principle awaits the test of subsequent events.

The narratological achievement of these eight chapters is to place different levels of event-making within one sequence: the handmade counter-map, an inset story drawn from historical oral tradition, readable app contracts, mysterious digital codes, the displacement of the authoritative centre through the 'second silence', the bodily rhythm of the festival of names, the shoot's many voices of meaning and the political time of the state's heritage tender. Source-faithful criticism must not assign equal evidentiary status to realism, folk belief, characters' allegations, private inference, written administrative notices and plans for the future. No event outside the original text is supplied here. The analysis remains centred on narrative time, the organization of place, focalisation, polyphonic dialogue, the difference between folk song and prose, repetitions of magical realism and genuine textual inconsistencies.

Critical Section 165 | Original Chapter 64 — Tendering Memory

The Language of Acquisition and a New Turn in the Narrative

At the end of Chapter 63, the municipality posted a notice concerning the heritage project; Chapter 64 transforms that brief notice into a systematic administrative tender. What changes in this progression is not so much the scale of the event as its meaning. The stump that served as the centre of the vigil over the dead people's names becomes ‘Site Parcel A’; the people's oral testimony becomes an ‘emotional heritage resource’. The narrator places the document's actual terminology alongside its effects upon local lives. Consequently, the conflict is no longer solely about rights over land: it becomes a struggle over the right to name.

The Notice Appears in Multiple Locations

The simultaneous appearance of similar notices on the tehsil wall, at the municipality, at the bus stand and on the unfinished bridge creates an impression of administrative omnipresence. In this compressed sequence of scenes, the voice of government has no single face; it seems to appear of its own accord from place to place. By contrast, the children's vigil over names arises from one particular location. The contrast between the spread of paper through public space and the gathering of people beside the stump is a principal technique for generating spatial tension. Posting the notice on the bridge connects the new project with the earlier deaths of labourers.

How Word Choice Makes Violence Invisible

Expressions such as ‘beautification’, ‘experience zone’, ‘sound design’ and ‘children's guide team’ recast a violent history as a collection of useful services. The narrator does not merely ridicule these terms; behind them remain the fragile rights attached to voices of suffering, bodies and lamentation. The possibility of converting the final telephone ring heard by Ujjwal's mother into a sound installation is the decisive example. The appropriation of memory begins by renaming the event, making its commodification possible thereafter.

Absences Revealed by the Cost Schedule

Saumya counts the budgetary provisions for lighting, branding, inauguration and consultancy, but finds little or nothing allocated to workers' rehabilitation, protection of privacy and the search for missing names. This reading constitutes a kind of narrative counter-map: the narrator makes the state's budget legible against the suffering of the people. The observation that ‘memory’ appears repeatedly while ‘name’

appears only rarely is not a statistical report; it is a satirical image of the distribution of value. Numbers take the place of persons, and the characters question that substitution.

Ananya's Question and the Inequality of Authority

'Will they invite bids for the names?' This child's question is the narrative centre of the entire tender episode. Devika explains the administrative language and makes its social consequences explicit, but the decisive question comes from a child. Focalisation thus shifts from the expert to a child's experience. The child cannot personally rewrite government regulations; nevertheless, her question prevents the official paper from remaining an unquestioned truth. The reader must recognise the document not as something natural but as an imposed arrangement.

Meera's Privacy and Ownership of the Record

On reading the provision for collecting oral material, Meera asks who will record the whispers of bereaved families. Here privacy emerges not as the opposite of public memory but as one of its legitimate limits. Access to information and authority over that information are different things. The earlier experiences of women in the narrative give Meera's position a basis in character; she is not merely a vehicle for an ethical pronouncement imported from outside the story. Her objection connects the right to look, the right to listen and permission to tell another person's story.

Aruni's Double Consciousness of Time

As Aruni reads the present tender, he remembers the earlier promises of safety, standards and labour welfare made for the bridge contract. This flashback is not an independent, elaborate retelling of past events, but a brief superimposition of memory. Readers are made to view the future of the new project in the light of the outcome of the old one. Bodies buried in the foundations of the bridge and photographs of the dead displayed in a memorial become successive forms of the same system of profit. This recurrence in narrative time is a structural resistance to social forgetting.

Batuknath Enters: Performing the Role of Saviour

Batuknath Hariharan arrives with a proposal for a 'People's Memory Trust'. The distance between his public humility and his desire to secure control over rights emerges through questions and answers. Proposals for a children's advisory committee and representation initially sound reasonable; yet the question of who will hold the real key to decisions remains unanswered. The narrator does not simply declare Batuknath a villain. Instead, his legal language is set against the rights of families,

children and workers. The gap between a lawful-looking framework and ethical responsibility becomes visible.

The Changing Rules of Kabaddi

During the evening game of kabaddi, the children replace the customary cry of 'kabaddi' with questions about the purpose of each sentence in the tender. The game brings opaque governmental language into the rhythm of the body. Breath is limited; long and obscure administrative answers cannot be sustained. The narrative converts critical thought from dialogue into action. To describe the game merely as a miraculous lesson would miss the emergence of a new collective method: play is becoming both a rehearsal of resistance and a public test of language.

The Invisible Signature and the Suspended Notice

A faint mark belonging to an international consultant emerges from the folded corner of the notice, pointing towards Edward Broom. The reader is not immediately given a certain documentary identification; suspicion takes shape through the memories of Gop and Aruni. This delayed disclosure of a name is both a device of suspense and a sign of an old wrongdoing taking a new disguise in the present. The trembling of the green point on the stump is a magical reflection of the political paper's effect, not independent objective evidence.

Song, Proverb and Narrative Distance

The opening song suggests a passage from mourning towards service, whereas the principal narrative shows mourning being exploited through the contracting-out of 'service'. Satire arises from the opposition between these two levels. The closing song again raises its voice against the sale of memory. The songs are not ethical sermons detached from the story: they return the meaning of events to the collective voice of the people. Nevertheless, critical distance must be maintained between the songs' explicit conclusions and the unresolved institutional situation within the action.

Conclusion: The Cost of Calling Grief a "Resource"

The decisive event of Chapter 64 is not simply the publication of the tender, but the beginning of the people's refusal of its vocabulary. The state's project has not been cancelled, nor has the trust fully exposed its intentions; the crisis remains open. The children's register begins to accumulate arguments as well as names. In this sense, the chapter prepares the confrontation between administrative documents and people's narrative for the reappearance of Broom in the following section.

Critical Section 166 | Original Chapter 65 — Broom's Return

The Smell of Old Greed: Olfaction as a Narrative Device

The chapter opens with the image of an "old smell" rising from the new tender. Smell cannot become a visible scene here, yet in Aruni's recollection it brings the old bridge, the dead labourers and the promises made on paper into the same instant. In an ordinary return episode a character first appears before the eyes; here his influence arrives earlier through smell, documents and familiar commercial language. This sequence turns Broom into something more enduring than an individual: a long-lived structure.

A New Company Name, Old Ownership Relations

Gop Kumar recognises signs of an old ownership relationship behind the foreign partner's new name. This recognition constitutes a disclosure, but no detailed legal proof has yet been made public. The information supplied by the narrator through the comparison of a character's memory with documents must be received by the reader with appropriate uncertainty. Concealing an old operation beneath a new name is a recurring economic strategy in the story. The reader's knowledge of the earlier bridge disaster makes it harder to regard this new undertaking as an innocent project.

The Museum versus Living Remembrance

Broom's proposal contains a glass structure, an artificial pond, fabricated crocodiles and a light show. The intention is to produce an exhibition replica of fear that is still lived. The image of the children's breath misting the glass reveals the profound loss involved in this transformation: visitors will watch the game inside but will not participate. The question posed by the institutionalisation of memory concerns not only money but the extinction of participation. A life that is continually spoken into presence cannot be reduced to a single spectacle for which tickets are sold.

Calling the Bridge Offence a "Misunderstanding"

In Broom's proposed dialogue, objections to the earlier project are described as a "misunderstanding". Within Aruni, the safety register, compensation, the names of workers and revisions to the contract come alive again. His silent anger at the word supplies the narrative's moral orientation. "Misunderstanding" is not an answer to the allegations but language that diminishes the magnitude of an offence. The narrator maintains a distance between the polite wording of documents and the

river's unsettled account, thereby increasing the reader's distrust of the language of public relations.

Financial Arrangements and the Families of the Dead

The proposed arrangements for donations, tickets, image collections and personal memorial records are not separate; they form a mutually reinforcing system. From her earlier experience of digital fraud, Devika recognises the potential network of profit. Meera rejects the sale of photographs and grief without permission. Criticism of an economic device becomes credible when it is situated in the practical rights of the families of the dead. In the narrative, the affected families are not passive objects of pity; they claim the right to determine the conditions of the proposal.

The Remembrance Spoken by an Elderly Woman of Sarayu's Lineage

An elderly woman calls the erasure of her husband's name after his death a second death. This utterance places physical death and social forgetting on different planes. To preserve a name behind glass and sell tickets is not to save the name, she asks, but to establish external control over its meaning. Lived experience emerges as a critical proposition. The scene turns the debate over ownership of the dead person's name from an abstract theoretical question into a consequence of prolonged domestic mourning.

A Child's Lota and the Impossibility of Collecting Life

An ordinary household object belonging to a child is set against the grand architecture of the memory project. The lota, a small water vessel, is not a museum exhibit in the story but a sign of everyday, continuing use. This modest object becomes an incomparable counterweight to the imposing glass building. Its critical importance lies in the way the narrative concentrates the outcome of an argument not only in a manifesto but in an object that can be touched and used. The object is small; the weight of its resistance is considerable.

A Character Enters through Correspondence

Broom does not immediately arrive in the village in person. His letter, colourful brochure and programme map perform the work of his presence. Through this epistolary presence, the character's "return" becomes an object of the reader's response before any actual encounter. The reader first sees Broom's public image and then its dismantling by local people. This interval in event-time forms a bridge to the arrival of the research team in the next chapter. The narrator postpones the antagonist's direct speech and foregrounds his indirect influence.

The Transformation of Printed Eyes

At night, the possibility arises that Broom's eyes in the brochure have become the eyes of a crocodile. Some characters say they see this; others regard it as an illusion. The narrator does not declare a scientifically verified event. Rather, collective fear and the memory of exploitation transform the meaning of the printed image. Magical realism does not construct a separate world beyond reality here; it gives experiential visibility to the predatory gaze concealed within a promotional portrait.

Foreshadowing the Visiting Research Team

On hearing that Broom's team is coming, Ananya resolves to ask: "Have you come to listen, or to write?" The structure of the next chapter is already concealed in this question. There is a possibility that Broom's capital, local administration and university research will be joined within one project. The narrative does not automatically treat research as an offence; it asks from whom researchers derive their right to observe and write. Preparation for this confrontation establishes the ground for a dramatic investigation.

The Recurrent Form of Return

The reappearance of an old figure between the bridge disaster and the memorial-heritage project is more than coincidence. The movement of money recurs from disaster to rescue, from rescue to memorial and from memorial to tourism. The plot thereby creates a circular economic time in which loss itself becomes the next business opportunity. Local attempts to interrupt that circle take the form of songs, questions and collective consent.

Conclusion: The True Nature of the Return

Chapter 65 is less the account of Broom's physical arrival than the story of his influence returning at several levels. Letters, signatures, consultation, digital proposals, routes of research and artificial nature are all repetitions of a single appropriation of memory. The narrative declares no decisive legal victory; instead it sets the terms by which the incoming research team will be tested. Return means not merely the reappearance of a person, but the persistence of an old offence even when its language has changed.

Critical Section 167 | Original Chapter 66 — The Harvard Research Team

The Arrival of Equipment and the Order of Seeing

Three vehicles, cameras, sound-recording equipment, tripods, identity cards and a grant coordinator distinguish the arrival of the research team from that of ordinary travellers. The instruments arrive first, as the means of seeing; the people come afterwards. The title, "The Harvard Research Team", signals institutional prestige, which the main narrative tests against the names of local people. The contrast between an abundance of equipment and limited preparedness to hear the victims' stories makes the narrative problem of research visible.

Ira's Intervention in the Structure of Time

The team arrives with questionnaires and a timetable; Ira instructs its members to sit in a circle and listen to the names first. Scheduled research time clashes with the community's time of mourning. The researchers want to ask questions immediately, while the village children first have them pronounce "present". At this moment the pace of narration is deliberately slowed. The reader must grasp not only information but also the conditions under which one becomes entitled to receive it.

Reordering the Word "Present"

The researchers struggle to pronounce "present". The word is not an answer in a data-entry form but a social pledge to the dead. An ordinary local word performs a greater ethical task than the complex vocabulary of a foreign questionnaire. The order of dialogue reverses power: university visitors become learners of meaning, while village children determine the conditions. The visitors are not represented as enemies of knowledge; rather, the insistence is that knowledge must begin by listening.

The Oral Story of Gangesha: A Dispute within the Narrative

The team is familiar with the writings of Gangesha Upadhyaya, but Ba raises stories of his uncomfortable social life. These historical claims are oral memories voiced by characters in the novel, not independently verified history. The narrator's actual work is to use such stories to expose a fissure between scholarly glory and caste exclusion. Criticism must preserve that distinction; the possibility that a claim is unverified is itself an unanswered question within the narrative.

The Research Question and the Community's Counterquestion

"A written source?" The researcher's question arises as a legitimate inquiry, but Ananya identifies the danger of allowing it to become a final verdict rather than the beginning of listening. The relationship between oral memory and archives is fraught, not wholly antagonistic. The story does not discard documents; it regards social context as necessary to their critical use. The epistemic positions of researcher, village witness and narrator remain distinct.

At the Widow's House: The Bodily Cost of Study

Although the team holds the village's map of memory, its members are led from the stump past the bridge and pond to a labourer's home. Mud on shoes, heat, fatigue and the crossing of a domestic threshold connect abstract study with bodily experience. This exercise does not provide a complete solution to research methodology. It does, however, initiate a living relationship in place of the distant image captured by a camera. Crossing physical distance becomes a possibility for diminishing ethical distance.

The Desire for an Image and the Decisive Refusal

When the labourer's widow sees the camera, she raises her eyes rather than automatically covering her face. The filmmaker takes this for a "rare" image and lifts the equipment; Meera stops him. The widow permits the recording of her husband's name, not the image of her own face. This is the chapter's climactic moment of characterisation. The same person separately refuses to be made an object of study and consents to become a speaking subject of the record. This distinction in consent becomes the ethical basis of the story's historical archive.

Saumya's Empty Pages and the Incompleteness of Research

The researcher's notebook does not fill as expected; many pages remain blank. This emptiness signifies not simply a failed study but the possibility of refraining from taking possession of a source. The narrator makes the unwritten page a meaningful object. The scene suggests that a victim's silence need not be converted into a quotation. This artistic device clearly anticipates the following chapter on the "right to look".

A New Kind of Silence from Satyavrat

Satyavrat Mehta does not use the authority of his office to take control of the entire discussion. On many earlier occasions his silence appeared as a delay in justice; now he wishes to preserve room for communal dialogue. A repeated word can acquire a changed meaning in the development of a character. This is a subtle use of recurrence. If a critic puts every silence into

the same moral category, an important line of character development disappears.

The Crocodile's Eye inside the Lens

In the final scene a crocodile's eye appears in the dust on the filmmaker's lens. At the realist level, the event might be an illusion or a trick of light; at the level of magical narrative, it is a metaphor for the predatory gaze. When someone attempts to seize an image without the subject's permission, the apparatus itself becomes the mouth of plunder. The priority given to instruments at the opening and the frightening transformation of an instrument at the end complete a circle.

The Relationship between Song and the Principal Episode

The opening song about "cleaning the lens" establishes in advance a rule of human dignity; the main narrative shows how that rule is broken in practice and learned only with difficulty. The closing song turns the narrative conflict into a collective warning. The song seems to know the ethical outcome beforehand, whereas the characters learn progressively. This difference in time gives the song the function of a prophetic chorus.

Conclusion: The Object of Study Has Changed

By the chapter's close, the research team's task has shifted from "collecting material" towards "examining its right to ask questions". This is no complete resolution: the team, its grant and institutional inequalities remain. Nevertheless, the widow's refusal and the pen halted by Ananya alter the initial conditions of study. In the next chapter, Meera will give this fractured research gaze an explicit public formulation.

Critical Section 168 | Original Chapter 67 — Meera and the Right to Look

The Body Enters the Central Question of the Story

In the preceding chapter, the raising of a camera was prevented; here the 'right to look' itself becomes the centre of the narrative. Meera brings to the dispute her experience of earlier violence, the invasive gaze that violated her privacy, and blackmail. Those experiences give her objection credibility grounded in the text. The discussion of rights is not an abstract lecture detached from the body, but a demand for control arising from her own experience. The title redirects the plot towards the individual's right to decide for herself.

Keeping Visitors Outside the Circle: Spatial Power

Ira stops the visiting team at the outer perimeter rather than allowing it into the inner circle around the stump. This small geographical alteration changes the narrative balance of power. Researchers are accustomed to measuring the community from a distance; here their own entry is subject to conditions. The circle is the recurring setting of Ananya's kabaddi, the vigil over names and collective decision-making. The conditions of entry turn it from an arena of record-keeping into a living structure of rights.

Why a Blurred Face Is Not Enough

A male researcher proposes the technical expedient of blurring faces. Meera asks who granted the prior right to take the image. Technical anonymisation and independent consent are not the same; the distinction is crucial to the narrative. Reducing the identifiability of an image does not automatically legitimise its capture, storage or circulation. The story makes consent an initial condition, not a correction that can be made afterwards.

No Monopoly over the Meaning of Silence

Meera explains at close quarters that 'yes', 'no' and silence are three distinct responses. The silence of a person being observed cannot automatically be treated as permission. Through this procedure, the narrator protects a character who does not speak. The relationship between language and the body is reversed here: visitors may pose numerous questions, but the authority to answer or not to answer rests with their subject. Amid social injustice, this small reversal constitutes an actual event in the development of the story.

Martha's Change and Its Limits

For the first time Martha, a member of the research team, asks, 'What should we do now?' She practises sitting beside the stump for twenty minutes without writing. The question has changed: where the researchers previously sought information from the community, she now wishes to understand the limits of her own conduct. But a single day's silence does not by itself erase institutional inequality. The story presents this decision as an opening. Meaningful ethical development will be measured by changes in research practice after a moment of humility.

Jagdish Ram's Claim to a Place within the Shastras

Jagdish Ram, a leatherworker, says that the stories of people excluded from the shastras demand a place within them. An account concerning Gangesha's marriage appears in the story as a disputed form of communal memory. Meera and Jagdish use it to criticise caste-based absence. The critic must understand the novel's statement as a character's historical consciousness, not as an independently established historical fact. This preserves the actual plurality of narrative voices.

The Relationship between Translation and the Gaze

Martha wants to understand Jagdish's words in her own language. Jagdish replies, 'First sit outside your own language.' This is not merely a declaration that translation is impossible; it resists the immediate appropriation of meaning. To hear another's suffering, the listener must suspend the haste of classification. The scene connects linguistic distance with the question of the right to look. The story does not reject translation; it questions the power exercised by impatient translation.

Twenty Minutes beside a Stone: The Expansion of Narrative Time

Meera instructs the visitors to sit beside a stone for twenty minutes without writing anything. The outward quantity of action is slight, but the experienced duration is long. In narratological terms, this deceleration prepares the reader for an act of feeling. A gaze held in suspension becomes more important than immediate depiction. The prescribed interval is a formal demonstration of patience towards the community's consent.

A Vigil over the Gaze: From Personal Injury to Social Rule

Meera's experience of violence against her body gives rise to her personal demand for privacy, but the children name the practice 'a vigil over the gaze'. One experience finds a place in a communal rule: this is the chapter's actual outcome. The groundwork for a later lesson in the school of leaves begins here. Education in this narrative does not start in a formal classroom; it emerges as the social translation of a victim's refusal.

The Suspended Action of Kabaddi

Ananya sounds the breathing rhythm of kabaddi, but the children do not immediately begin to play. This suspension is meaningful. The game is being transformed from the bodily act of grasping into a rule governing the grasp of the gaze. Here the recurring sign of kabaddi is not celebration but an anticipation of discipline. Even the absence of play becomes the formation of a new ethical rule for the game.

The Female Voice in the Folk Song

The folk song 'Permission First' sings the principle of consent before the chapter's events unfold. The principal narrative shows that putting this principle into practice requires stopping someone's camera, interrupting someone's question and respecting someone's silence. The song announces the outcome; the story depicts the labour required to reach it. Together these two levels transform the female voice from decorative song into an operative right.

Final Assessment: The Difficulty of a Just Gaze

The chapter offers a clear principle concerning the right to look, yet institutional transformation is not complete. The research team is still present and the promotional scheme continues. Meera does not deliver a final solution; she changes the conditions under which conversation may begin. 'Looking' now proceeds by recognising the boundary of another person's freedom rather than treating that person as its object. This prepares the ethical basis for the criticism of the digital application in the next chapter.

Critical Section 169 | Original Chapter 68 — Devika versus the Memorial App

The Digital Gateway to Mourning

In Chapter 68 the memorial application opens with a deceased person's name, image, messages, a lamp of remembrance and a gentle invitation to donate. The narrator does not initially conceal its appeal: digital access is presented as potentially useful to families living far away. Devika then examines the form's questions, mandatory fields and path to donations. The opposition between tender language and subtle commercial control is the chapter's central narrative tension. The surface convenience of technology and its deeper social risks are revealed in stages.

The Form's Boxes and the Erasure of Persons

The application asks for the deceased person's father's name, family structure, caste, date of death, mobile number and other details. Names belonging to people whose fathers are unknown, whose families are displaced, whose identities remain incomplete or upon whom social conventions have been imposed cannot fit its standard. Devika identifies the discrimination built into this design. Rather than merely exhibiting a technical error, the story questions the power of classification. Declaring a complex life's name 'invalid' reproduces social exclusion through technical procedure.

Ujjwal's Name and the Insensitivity of Marketing

In a back office, the words 'high emotional reach' appear beside Ujjwal's name. This scene delivers the chapter's sharpest ethical shock. The family remembers the young man's death in terms of social and digital exploitation, while the app converts their grief into a score of potential market influence. Devika does not immediately take a photograph; her restraint is itself part of the criticism. Even while seeking evidence of wrongdoing, she refuses to seize another victim's privacy.

Chandrapal's Language of 'Convenience'

Chandrapal Batra presents his application as a service and calls the rejection of incomplete names 'cleaning'. Devika detects the market's convenience within this 'cleaning': disconnected or incomplete details generate less profit. In this dialogue, the character's own speech exposes his desire for power. Rather than assigning the antagonist a melodramatic villain's speech, the narrator has him express the logic of exploitation in ordinary managerial terms. The normalised form of wrongdoing thus emerges.

The Screen and the Crocodile Metaphor

Devika feels that a crocodile has emerged from the river and opened its mouth within the words. This image is not a precise account of a living crocodile's behaviour but a metaphor for a human-made system of digital profit. Across the larger narrative, the crocodile signifies at different moments an aquatic creature, greed or absent memory. Here its mouth opens through the language of 'approved name', 'donation', 'cleaning' and 'emotional reach'. The transfer of the metaphor connects the animal of the work's title to a critique of social structures.

Respect for Victims and Devika's Restraint in Reporting

Devika describes the app's operations at a village meeting, but does not publicly disclose every name on the confidential list she has seen. This choice is an ethical example of the transmission of information within the story. Exposing injustice and protecting victims' confidentiality can coexist: the narrative demonstrates this through action. The character's credibility grows not only from her incisive statements but from her capacity to withhold information that would be easy to publicise.

The Children Formulate a New Rule

After the meeting, the children decide that no name will be placed on a screen without the family's permission. Where no immediate relative can be identified, the name will be subject to a communal hearing. This rule attempts to balance the public character of individual grief with collective responsibility. The plot advances from mourning for the past towards the construction of an institutional response. Disagreement within families, unknown relationships and the deceased person's own wishes nevertheless remain unresolved; criticism must note these limits.

The Collective Act of Turning Phones Face Down

Ananya places the phones face down among the stones bearing names. This small scene physically reverses digital authority. The screens' glow is extinguished and the stones become visible; technology is not abandoned altogether but temporarily subordinated. Before the collective pledge 'names will not be sold' becomes a publicity slogan, it is supported by a bodily act. The opposition between stones and mobile phones constructs the material grammar of the story.

Scraped Letters: From Digital Theft to Physical Theft

The following morning, the letters on three stones bearing names are found to have faded. The earlier discussion no longer remains merely a critique of an app; its effects reach the site around the stump. The narrator does not immediately identify the thief. Instead, the scraped stones, their

warm surfaces and the warning of an old ghost open a new mystery. This delayed revelation of causes allows readers to consider a possible connection between digital profit and social erasure, while the thief's actual identity remains unknown.

The Function of the Folk Song

The opening children's song teaches the practice of stopping to think before pressing a button. Devika enacts precisely this pause in the principal story: she reads the form, examines the names, refrains from taking a photograph and shares limited information at the public meeting. The song's instruction becomes action. The closing song draws a satirical connection between 'button' and 'pocket', fixing the diversion of digital mourning towards profit in the reader's memory.

Information, Power and Focalisation

The chapter's principal information reaches the reader through Devika's investigation; Chandrapal offers only a limited defence. This restricted focalisation reveals the system gradually and reduces the risk of turning it into a mere inventory supplied by an omniscient narrator. The withholding of certain confidential details from the reader is also consistent with the story's ethical method. The deliberately maintained boundary between the knowledge of narrator and character makes reporting a story about practical choices.

Conclusion: The Question of Who Owns a Name

Chapter 68 establishes that a dispute over the rights to memory cannot be settled by technical improvements to an app. The question is where legitimate authority to make a deceased person's name public resides. The ease with which a digital mark can be copied is placed in narrative opposition to a family's prolonged grief. The erasure of letters on the stones at the end actively prepares the ground for the next section, 'The Theft of Names'.

Critical Section 170 | Original Chapter 69 — The Theft of Names

The First Scene of an Invisible Crime

The chapter opens with a warning that the exploitation captured on a screen is only the visible portion of the actual theft. It then depicts the erasure of letters from the stones bearing names. The objects, the red thread and the location remain where they were; only the names are absent. Here the narrator makes the object of the crime almost imperceptible. Theft comes to mean not the removal of property but the erasure of social identity, history and the very possibility of raising questions.

The Blank Surface of the Stone and the Rebirth of Grief

Sarayu Mandal's stone is found in its place, but its inscription has disappeared. This scene is a poignant metaphor for material emptiness. People experience something like another death because the social existence of the name is being effaced. In the narrative, mourning does not end with the occurrence of a death; a change in the record brings it to life again. Through this recurrence, the notion of a "second death" acquires a concrete scene.

Conflicting Records

In the digital list, Sarayu is recorded as "unverified", a labourer's death as "unavailable", and Ujjwal's incident as "voluntary risk". These expressions, couched in different administrative language, stand in opposition to the living testimony of the people. At this moment, the reader can no longer regard a document as a neutral instrument of remembrance. The narrator sets particular names alongside one another: collective utterance and institutional anonymisation proceed in parallel within the same sequence of scenes.

Saumya Changes the Title

Saumya first writes "The Theft of Names" and then changes it to "Organised Oblivion Directed against Names". This hesitation on the writer's part is itself part of the narrative. The offence of a single thief and collective institutional erasure belong to different levels. Rewriting the title reveals the changing dimensions of the analysis: the more of the incident is seen, the more difficult it becomes to name. The author stages the act of critical naming within the event itself.

The Trust Proposal Returns

Batuknath Hariharan again proposes an "organised" People's Memory Trust. When memory is being destroyed on the stones, the argument that a secure institution is needed sounds plausible. Yet it comes accompanied by proposals concerning chairmanship, ownership and expert control. The narrator gives the problem two sides: an institution may be necessary at some level to protect public memory, but the institution itself may become an instrument of appropriation. A simple conclusion of acceptance or rejection is avoided.

The Public Meaning of an Incomplete Name

Ananya and the children insist that records should leave room for incomplete names. A digital system demands a complete father's name, date of birth and verifiable data; in communal memory it is entirely possible that someone's actual name remains incomplete. The question is not whether every unsupported claim should be accepted. It is why uncertainty should be excluded from the record. In the narrative, "incompleteness" emerges as an inconvenient but necessary witness.

Chandrapal's Surveillance from Afar

Chandrapal watches the scene on his mobile phone, while his application issues an alert: "Invalid name reactivated". In the village, a name returns through the voices of the people; the machine in the city treats its return as an error. This parallel scene establishes two centres of perception: communal remembrance and commercial control. Remote digital surveillance divides the narrative's geography while retaining a causal connection between its locations. The renewed utterance of a name itself puts pressure on the limits of the app.

A Wet Figure Beneath the Stone

When the stone bearing Sarayu's name is lifted, a shape in the soil resembling a map of a pond is found beneath it. The scene generates the setting of the next chapter from the present event. Instead of issuing a direct command to "go to the pond", the author lets a natural mark concealed beneath the absence of a name point the way. This pivot of magical realism links the fixed stone to a story of flowing water.

The Old Ghost and the Possibility of Natural Testimony

The Old Ghost says that erased names may remain in the water. This statement should be read as a belief within the story and a magical suggestion, not as a guaranteed substitute for external, objective records. Its narrative effect is nonetheless concrete: the place of inquiry shifts from office papers to the edge of the pond. The characters are changing their

understanding of whom they should approach to ask about the community's truth.

The Song's Vision of Recovery

The opening water-drawing song imagines the "erased name" rising again like a lotus. In the main narrative, however, the name has not yet been recovered; only a clue to its possible location has been found. The difference between the hopeful rhythm of the folk song and the incomplete outcome of the mystery keeps the critical section alive. The song supplies an emotional horizon of anticipated resolution, while the sequence of events demands several further stages of examination before reaching it.

The Extended Meaning of the Crocodile Metaphor

In this chapter the crocodile does not attack people directly. Its function is distributed across systems that erase names, documentary silence and commercial ownership. The disappearance of a name while the stone survives is an especially subtle action of a devouring power. In reading such a metaphor, criticism must distinguish human exploitation from the natural existence of living aquatic creatures. The metaphor concerns an unethical system, not the moral culpability of an actual animal.

Conclusion: From Evidence of Theft to the Momentum of a Search

At the end of the section, Ananya writes, "Tomorrow we shall listen to the pond." This sentence creates a clear forward point in narrative time. Earlier uncertain suspicions turn into a decision to undertake a collective inquiry. The theft has not ended, nor has the thief been caught; nevertheless, the people actively begin a search by changing the place from which they seek testimony. This movement makes the following section, "The Testimony of the Water-Dweller", narratively necessary.

Critical Section 171 | Original Chapter 70 — The Testimony of the Water-Dweller

From Documents to the Edge of the Pond

The closing words of Chapter 69, "We shall listen to the pond", become the practical beginning of the next event. The overnight crisis of names, the children's unease and the blurred letters, alternately intelligible and unintelligible, draw the people to the pond. The change of place is meaningful: after the records office, the stones beside the stump and the mobile screen, water itself becomes a new surface of narration. Place is not merely a backdrop; it offers a new possibility of information.

The Water-Dweller's Presence in Folklore

The people variously regard the water-dweller inhabiting the pond as a woman, a ghost or a living creature. The effect of magical realism rests upon this very uncertainty. At the outset the narrator does not supply a definitive zoological identity; the being's presence is constructed among the community's shifting beliefs. What matters about the water-dweller is not classification but the role of bearing witness to erased names. Here folk belief gives the community another opportunity to listen.

The Script of Water: Reflections and Remains

Bubbles, leaves, the movement of fish, the fractured image of the moon and wet earth all become signs of the water-dweller's testimony. Minute occurrences take the place of letters. This is not a record written in the scientific language of nature but a multivalent visual grammar created by the narrator. Entering such signs into a register extends communal remembrance; it does not automatically verify anyone's historical claims.

The Pledge of Privacy Becomes a Rule of Water

At the pond's edge, Meera first makes clear that no one's face or weeping will be displayed by force. The water-dweller likewise says that turning suffering into an exhibition does not protect a name. In this way, nature's narrative voice reiterates a social rule of consent. The magical character does not displace the experiences of the human characters; it enlarges their significance. The boundary of privacy remains intact even in this watery setting.

Satyavrat Speaks and Falls Silent

Satyavrat Mehta remarks upon the possibility of testimony in the reflection on water and then falls silent again. He does not exercise the character's former judicial authority; instead, he leaves the community

room to determine meaning. His limited intervention is bound up with the pacing of narration: one observation opens a profound question without forcing a public conclusion. This subtle shift carries forward the character's journey towards a "second silence".

The Screen's Lie Breaks upon the Water

A fraudulent donation page opens by itself on Gop's phone. When reflected in the pond, its letters and account numbers seem to distort and dart away like fish. The scene is simultaneously a magical image and an ethical metaphor for digital deception. The fixed image of the screen loses its control upon the changing surface of water. It would be wrong to describe this simply as a technical means of fact-checking: it is a sensory counterstatement within the novel.

The Collective Discipline of Listening

Beside the pond, people speak the names one by one, respect the permission of families and attentively observe the water's subtle responses. Elements of an assembly, a ritual and children's play come together in this sequence. Unlike a crowd of ordinary spectators, this community practises restraining its gaze, opening its ears and accepting incomplete signs. Without this collective preparation to listen, the water-dweller's "testimony" would not acquire its narrative meaning.

The Old Ghost's Limited Mediation

The Old Ghost emerges from the reeds and once again recalls the connection between breath and names. He is not an omniscient arbiter of the dispute but a guardian of the old rules of the people's game. His voice does not offer the characters a complete solution to the mystery of the testimony. Instead, he reiterates the need to practise kabaddi. The narrator does not make a supernatural mediator a substitute for the work of the human community.

From Social Memory to Natural Memory

The theft of names was first shown in digital and governmental records; now references appear in water, fish, leaves and the moon's reflection. This shift grants the living world a narrative place as a partner in human memory. The environment is not merely a beautiful picture; within story time it becomes a possible bearer of past events. Yet the signs in the water do not have a single, linear meaning: they invite multiple interpretations.

The Festival Poster: Exploitation's Immediate Counterattack

The following morning a bright poster advertising a "Ghost-Kabaddi Festival" appears. Turning the previous night's deep communal listening

into a marketable "extraordinary folk experience" the next day is the central conflict of narrative time in this chapter. Here capital does not merely seek to destroy popular resistance; it imitates its popular symbols and returns them to the market. The story makes visible the race between competing systems of remembrance.

The Opening Song and Unresolved Testimony

The song of a "name freed from entanglement" inspires hope of liberation, while the main narrative retains the plurality of signs and uncertainty of their meaning. Both popular hope and critical caution are necessary within this duality. The song gives rhythm to the community's future work, but it is not an incontrovertible record of events. The distance constructed by the narrator offers an opportunity to resist reading the magical scene as a simple declaration of fact.

Outcome: Risk Persists after Testimony

Even after the water-dweller's voice has been heard, the crisis of names has not been fully resolved. Those concretely responsible for the original offence remain unidentified, and the commercialisation of memory returns in the form of a new poster. The achievement here is the expansion of communal listening; its limitation lies in the persistence of documentary injustice and economic power. The next chapter, "The Procession of False Ghosts", will test this achievement in the marketplace of performance.

Critical Section 172 | Original Chapter 71 — The Procession of False Ghosts

Purchased Smoke and the Public Performance of Ghosts

The festival begins with a municipal permit, artificial smoke, makeup, lighting equipment and five performers. The pond's uncertain testimony in the previous chapter is now being prepared for sale as a definite, staged "experience". The narrator shows the apparatus that produces the smoke, allowing the reader, before the audience, to know that the ghostly display has been planned. This is dramatic irony: the spectators within the performance and the reader outside it acquire knowledge at different speeds.

The Organiser's Promise of Development

The organiser speaks the language of employment, tourism and the promotion of memory. Rather than immediately opposing this claim with an administrative decision, the narrator sets it against a personal question. Meera asks whether the families of the dead have given their consent. The organiser acknowledges that no names will be spoken; only an "atmosphere" will be created. This answer contains a striking gap: grief may be sold as a representation even without naming the bereaved. In this next form of exploitation, the decorative "setting" of pain, rather than the individual, becomes the commodity.

Ananya's Decision Not to Stop It

Ira asks whether the procession can be stopped, but Ananya decides to watch first. This is an important narrative choice. The community chooses not an immediate prohibition but the possibility of witnessing the failure within the performance itself. The children are learning a new method of resistance through the language of play. Yet the decision is not without risk: the counterfeit celebration can wound the memory of the dead. The narrative does not erase that discomfort.

Artificial Breath and the Rhythm of Real Kabaddi

The false ghosts make the sounds of kabaddi, but their breath soon breaks. What the community had made into a rhythm for guarding names becomes a merely technical sound in the tourist spectacle. The breaking of breath symbolises the incongruity of the actors' arrangement. They cannot sustain the watch over names without remembering suffering. The attempt to appropriate the magical form of the game through imitation is thereby shown to be incomplete in itself.

The First Real Name Outside the Script

A performer's foot lands on an exposed root, and instead of the written dialogue, the name of his father, who died in a mine, escapes his mouth. This is the decisive event of the chapter. The artificial stage of the game suddenly becomes connected to a real memory of labour. The event is presented as a supernatural touch, but the name's social ground is the performer's own family grief. At the instant the costume of the script breaks apart, the narrator brings forth a new speaker: a body hired to dance becomes an independent witness.

The Gradual Emergence of Plural Testimonies

After the first performer, another speaks of a mother's name erased from a pension register; a third recalls a hospital bill; and a dance teacher tells of a love that had to remain suppressed. Distinct circumstances of life come together on the same stage. The scene may look like a list, but its sequence clarifies a transformation of function: performance ceases to be an exhibition emptied of suffering and becomes spontaneous testimony. Each additional voice weakens the organiser's command not to depart from the script.

The Dramatic Reversal within the Procession

The organiser intended to give the spectators a frightening display; the performers begin speaking the truths of their lives. Through this reversal, the story turns the performance itself into a site of resistance. The external stage is not removed; the right to speak from it changes hands. The definition of "false" does not attach to the actor. False is the script that seeks to turn grief into entertainment. The actors themselves can become bearers of truth.

The Absent-Witness Role of the Real Ghosts

Ba says that the real ghosts sat beside the water and watched without becoming angry. The narrator does not close this reported scene as a definitely witnessed event. Through it, however, the ghosts' role changes: earlier they taught the people the rules of the game; now the people begin naming their own sorrows. The old supernatural guardians watch the birth of human witnesses. That is a structural advance in the narrative.

Ananya's Response: Not Punishment, but Learning to Keep Watch

Ananya does not drive the performers away. She says the acting was false, but the names spoken were true. By making this distinction, the character shapes a new form of communal justice. Blame is not reduced to a simple denunciation of individuals; the creative transformation of their experience is treated as possible. The relationship between art and life is

restored, but the organiser responsible for paid exploitation is not thereby declared innocent.

The Weight of the Artificial Costumes

At the end of the programme, the performers remove their black costumes and place them beside the stones bearing names. The garments, once light theatrical clothing, seem heavy and soaked. Through this physical metaphor, the weight of suffering remains even after the play ends. The performers have ceased acting, but a father's death, a mother's erased name and the fear surrounding love have not suddenly disappeared. The narrative does not simplify a dramatic revelation into immediate forgiveness or resolution.

The Laughing Tree: The Final Transformation of Sound

At midnight, the sound rising from within the stump is neither weeping nor wind, but laughter. Ba explains its meaning: when memory survives despite attempts to sell it, the tree laughs. This narrative sound points from the fear-driven ghost kabaddi towards a new manifestation of autonomous resistance. The source of the sound remains uncertain; its meaning arises from the community's experience. In this way, the ending of one chapter gives birth to the title of the next.

Conclusion: Recovering Truth from the Counterfeit

The outcome of Chapter 71 is more than the defeat of a counterfeit procession staged for tourists. The right to testify passes from the organiser to the performers and the community of children. Once the terms of performance have changed, spectacle becomes an opening to remembrance. The social outcome remains incomplete: municipal permission, the networks of profit and offers of donations are still in place. Nevertheless, the laughing stump opens a new narrative sequence of resistance. Through that sound, the next chapter, "The Laughter of the Channa Tree", enters directly and naturally into the story.

The Next Stage of the Critical Study: Original Chapters 72–91

Critical Sections 173–192

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Critical Section 173 | Original Chapter 72 — The Laughter of the Channa Tree

Narrative Transition from the Previous Procession to Laughter

The exposure of the false-ghost procession in Chapter 71 is transformed here into the laughter of the stump. The failure of the spectacle does not bring the story to an end; it opens a further phase of collective listening. The source of the laughter remains suspended among three possibilities: wind, a hollow in the wood and a supernatural presence. The narrator does not determine the cause. Through this suspension, the Channa tree changes from the site of events into a contested narrative witness. The reader continues to ask whether laughter was heard or its social meaning was created.

The Children's Register and a Place That Tells Its Own Story

As soon as "The Laughter of the Channa Tree" is entered as a title in the children's register, the place seems to begin telling its story for itself. This adds another layer of recording over the directly witnessed occurrence. The children occupy all three roles: writers, editors and listeners. The protagonist's authority moves from a single individual into the hands of the group compiling the register. The chapter does not suggest that the register merely describes events; it gives events a continuing form in communal memory.

The Stump's Sound: Constructing Nonhuman Agency

The felled tree becomes a living character, but its agency should not be dismissed simply as a "miracle". The narrator shows three material signs separately: a slight vibration, a line appearing on the stone and the persistence of the sound after the wind has stopped. The sense that the roots have survived is connected later with a new shoot. The tree's narrative presence alters the human practice of listening. It is therefore no longer environmental background but an active place that preserves memory.

Ananya's and Ba's Different Ways of Hearing

Ananya understands the tree's laughter as an answer; Ba connects it with a voice refusing suffering. The two statements speak different languages of experience: the first opens the possibility of dialogue, the second expresses a memory opposed to exploitation. The story does not summon an omniscient judge to reconcile these perspectives. The short exchange brings two histories of lived experience beside the same stump, shifting the

reader's attention from the sound's cause to the social conditions of its reception.

The Visual Ambiguity of Changing Letters on Stone

The darkening of certain letters and the appearance of a new dot beside an incomplete name render the scene uncertain. Within the episode, these changes are narrated as particular visual observations, but not as externally verified scientific findings. From a critical standpoint, their function is to bring the incompleteness of names into view. Where the record is incomplete, memory cannot be regarded as settled. The new mark on the surface of the stone gives material form to the narrative's ethical unease.

Saumya Closes Her Notebook: The Right to Quote

Seeing an opportunity to include a quiet-spoken girl's response in a research paper, Saumya asks permission. The girl asks whether those who read it will also listen. Saumya closes her notebook. In this silence, the novelist questions the right of critics, researchers and writers to represent other people. A clever quotation on the page cannot take the place of the ethical responsibility to listen. The scene may also be read as the novel's self-examination of its own creative method.

The App's Failed Attempt to Capture Sound

Chandrapal's team tries to record the stump's sound secretly, but the recording contains an emptiness. Each listener hears within it different words connected to their own wrongdoing. The failure of technical objectivity is constructed through narrative art, not offered as a proposition about actual engineering. As the sound proves impossible to sell, the account of digital commodification becomes evidence against itself. The paradox of many accusatory voices heard within a blank recording is a distinctive magical-realist device in this chapter.

Raghav's Changing Code: Linguistic Resistance to Information Control

Raghav writes encoded messages about crowd risk and the control of the story, but the words repeatedly return as resistance by the story itself. In this scene the claim to control code collides with the freedom of narrative language. The reader witnesses not a machine fault but a dramatic resistance of words. Erasing the same sign three times makes it recur; repetition heightens the intensity of fear. The scene also foreshadows the subsequent narrative of a network disconnection.

Broom's Sound Tourism: Healing as a Commercial Form

Broom's adviser wants to turn the laughter into a project under the attractive terms "community healing" and "memory tourism". There is a discrepancy between the report's technical terminology and Broom's private experience of hearing. Amid applause during a Harvard lecture, he hears the stump's laughter; coffee tastes to him like earth. These personal sensations open a fissure in the lustre of institutional vocabulary. The story attacks the language of profit not through direct preaching but through a disturbance of experience.

Meera's Notice: A Counter-Manifesto of Resistance

Meera states that no one owns laughter and that the pain of the dead and the testimony of the living are not for sale. This declaration is hung beside the stump within the story: resistance, too, becomes a public written text. The memorial company's contract and the community's manifesto compete in the same place as rival forms of writing. Meera's concern with privacy extends a narrative strand begun with the earlier misuse of images; her voice is therefore not an isolated slogan.

The Journalists' Questions and a Plural Narrative Centre

A journalist asks, "Does the tree really laugh?" Ananya changes the terms of the question: "Truth or spectacle?" Another journalist asks for the principal story, but a child insists upon many names. This scene directly interrogates the claim that a plot must have a single centre. The novel rejects the convenience of enclosing everyone's story under one headline. The notebook that returns empty is not a rejection of journalism; it symbolises a new understanding of the priority of listening.

Kabaddi's Breath and the Shared Rhythm of Memory

Attention turns from artificial smoke to the real vapour of the players' breath. The old players of ghost kabaddi teach the rule of sharing breath within remembrance. Saying "came back having listened" instead of "survived" changes the vocabulary of outcomes: the game's victory gives way to collective listening. The half-visible presence of ghosts, the haze of moonlight and the image of feet falling upon a row of names bring folklore and history into the same embodied rhythm.

The Shoot Becomes an Ear: Transformation of an Image

The green point on the stump spreads a little, and the shape of the new leaf resembles an ear. This growth is not an instant, miraculous solution in the form of restored greenery; it extends the metaphor of listening into plant life. The ear appearing before the leaf changes the narrative sequence: first the capacity to listen sensitively, and only then the claim to renewed life.

The image succeeds because environmental return and social responsibility no longer remain separate scenes.

The Final Narrative Handover to the Dream Court

At the chapter's end, a stump grows in Batuknath's chest, and in a dream he receives a summons to a hearing concerning his own trust. The outward collective struggle enters an inward moral conflict. The final sentence clearly prepares the next chapter's event, but does not yet declare the outcome of justice. Through this gradual handover, the novel keeps the same fundamental image active in three fields: the municipality, the digital marketplace and private conscience.

Critical Section 174 | Original Chapter 73 — Batuknath's Dream Court

An Extension of the Dream at the Previous Chapter's Close

The stump that grew in Batuknath's chest in Chapter 72 becomes an elaborate dream court in this chapter. This is no abrupt, separate episode: it develops in sequence from the earlier laughter, the draft trust deed and the children's questions. The story's external action is confined to a single night, while Batuknath's memories and fears traverse many years. Through this simultaneous contraction and expansion of time, the psychological narrative grows more intense than an account of an external trial.

The Visual Reversal of the Word "Trust"

As Batuknath writes "People's Memory Trust", he sees the ink spread like a pond. The letters designating clauses, offices and funds turn into leaves. This narrative transformation of paper exposes the desire to acquire institutional ownership over memory. The author places in crisis not the legitimate existence of legal provisions, but the aspiration to use them as instruments of control. The page becoming a leaf, and the table becoming a stump, are techniques that carry the image from material objects into a moral atmosphere.

The Hesitant Boundary Between Waking and Dreaming

Laughter and the transformations of ink and paper appear before sleep begins; the letters of the draft are still altered after awakening. The entire strangeness therefore cannot be dismissed with the words "it was only a dream". The story deliberately leaves the boundary between the dream experience and waking objects partly open. In that uncertainty the reader is drawn, not towards a definitive explanation, but into the pressure exerted by Batuknath's experience.

The Dramatic Dissolution of the Courtroom's Architecture

The high chair of the Bar Council becomes a root, certificates of honour fall like leaves, and a polished table turns into wet bark. The geography of institutional power is overcome by a geography of roots and soil. The sequence is as swift as a film, but its significance runs deep: the narrator reinstates the buried time of ordinary lives in the elevated space of the court. The change of smell makes the scene more than visual decoration; it becomes a displacement experienced through the senses.

Gangesha as a Dream Character: The Limits of Narrative Function

In the dream, Gangesha appears not as a straightforward biographical account of an enduring historical figure, but as an interrogating character fashioned from Batuknath's guilt. References to his supposed life events, caste conflict and marriage cannot demand the status of independently verified history from the reader: they belong to the dream narrative. The critical question here is not a historical examination of the evidence concerning Gangesha, but the authority of his voice within the dream and its narrative effect upon Batuknath's mind.

The Caste Fence: Social Hierarchy as a Visible Metaphor

In the dream court, the hierarchy between Brahmin and leatherworker takes the tangible form of a fence and a raised seat. A woman leatherworker pulls out the bamboo posts of the fence; she is not the silent subject of an argument but an agent who changes the scene. By means of this dramatic action, the novel turns an abstract conception of caste into a structure that can be touched. Batuknath's fear is also bound to the fence: the division of society seems to him like a system of personal protection.

The Dream of Editing a Biography and the Contradiction of Honour

In the dream, the shadows of two literary names stage the cutting away of inconvenient portions of Gangesha's life. This must not be mistaken for evidence of the actual conduct of writers outside the text; the scene belongs to the narrator's dream perspective. Its narrative centre is the contradiction, "The statue survived; the human being was cut away." Within the dream, the novel criticises the excision of inequality and rebellion when a life is edited into an exemplary icon.

One Charge in the Prosecution and the Many Debts of the Case

The charge against Batuknath contracts from a catalogue of offences into one concentrated accusation: turning away from justice in the name of his profession. This concentration transforms the scene from a forensic exchange into the character's moral hearing of himself. A widow's sold jewellery, the death of a witness, dates of adjournment and the waiting of the poor emerge in visible form. This succession of small consequences changes the lifeless time of case files into human injury.

The Collective Cry of "Present" and a Counter-Narrative

The stump, the children, Ba, Meera, Devika, Aruni, Satyavrat and other voices form the shared rhythm "We are present" within the dream. Set against the language of formal defence, this brief declaration creates a collective counter-narrative. The diversity of witnesses matters: no single character speaks in the place of everyone. What the reader witnesses is not

a settled definition of evidence, but a structural event in which voices formerly absent are given seats within the story.

Childhood Memory: The Prehistory of Judicial Conduct

Batuknath remembers a separate drinking vessel in his home, a child sitting outside the schoolroom and a prohibition imposed by his mother. The roots of his present conduct in court are shown to lie in the social discipline of his childhood. This retrospection does not treat the character's wrongdoing as a simple inborn trait; it reconstructs the history of conduct he has learned. But an explanation of causes is not forgiveness. The chapter leaves his responsibility for his present professional decisions intact.

The Question of the Girl Carrying a Name-Stone

In the dream a girl, who may be Ananya or her shadow, asks what place an excluded person will have in the trust. This uncertainty of identification belongs to the method of dreaming. Rather than standing for one individual alone, the girl becomes the collective voice of those guarding names. Batuknath's inability to answer constitutes the scene's judgment. The narrator does not announce a sentence; the scene exposes his incapacity to listen.

The Kabaddi Boundary and the Broken Breath

The lines of the game shine across the courtroom ceiling; the old ghost challenges Batuknath to cross the boundary. He cannot finish uttering "kabaddi": his breath catches. This physical failure becomes a concentrated symbol opposing the fluent language of legal advocacy. The man who kept others outside the game cannot himself sustain its necessary rhythm. This image of breath supplies the formal basis for the pressure towards confession in the following episode.

The Waking Draft: Reform or Disguised Transformation?

On waking, Batuknath finds "last listener" where an office title stood, the children's watch in place of the fund, and an injunction that memory cannot be sold in place of property. Yet the narrator does not say that Batuknath's old cunning has disappeared. Practical reform remains uncertain even after the language of the draft changes in the dream. This incomplete development of character deepens the novel's ethical complexity: the imagining of remorse and the act of assuming responsibility are different things.

Chandrapal's Note in the Cupboard and the Next Wrongdoer

Opening an old file, Batuknath finds a note from Chandrapal marked "memorial app secured". After the dream, this real paper directs the narrative towards its next concrete character. The laughter of the stump enters Chandrapal's screen as though along an invisible connecting thread. By linking external narrative action with inner experience, this transition foreshadows Chapter 74; the dream does not remain a detached subplot.

Critical Section 175 | Original Chapter 74 — Chandrapal's First Confession

Setting: From the Metropolis of Cold Glass to the Name-Stones

The narrative moves from Batuknath's room into Chandrapal's expensive, air-conditioned city home. Its glass table, numerous phones, imported liquor and security arrangements mark his social distance. Yet within that coldness sweat gathers on his nose and his heartbeat quickens. His subsequent journey in an old car towards the village gradually brings this remote character among damp straw, soil and the children's silence. The change of place supplies an outward, dramatic picture of his developing character.

The Gradual Shift of Vision from Crowds to Persons

In his business Chandrapal has reduced human beings to figures for each click, donation and unit of fear. At night the numerical rows on his mobile phone turn back into the names of the dead, labourers and families. Through this image the story portrays an inward crisis in the way he sees. The principal issue is not that the figures are incorrect, but that the human beings missing from those figures become central to the plot. The return of names breaks through his habitual pretence of neutrality.

Many Eyes in the Mirror: A Sensory Structure of Guilt

In the bathroom mirror Chandrapal sees many eyes belonging to exploited people instead of his own face. The sight is not established as an externally verifiable event; it is a marvel arising within monologue and fear. These multiple eyes turn a private face into the site of collective scrutiny. Seeing oneself through the gaze of others becomes the narrative's new point of view. Within this image, the character's isolation and his social responsibility collide in a single instant.

"I Never Laid a Hand on Them": The Moral Collapse of Distance

Chandrapal repeats the defence that he committed no direct physical violence. The story follows it with the question of who tied the ropes of fear. The excuse that digital fraud, emotional exploitation and the role of an intermediary can be separated from responsibility for what happened begins to disintegrate. Crucially, the narrator does not occupy a fixed position of sermonising authority; instead, he repeatedly lets the wrongdoer's old self-justifying words be heard from within. The breakdown of this repetition marks a turning point in the character's time.

The Distance Between Private Fear and Genuine Remorse

The narrator makes clear that the wrongdoer first imagines the loss of his money, passport and reputation. Chandrapal's initial trembling cannot therefore be called complete moral reform. This self-critical distance is one of the chapter's important strengths. Time is needed between recognising one's fault and understanding the harm borne by those affected. Resisting the enchantment of tearfulness, the story directs the reader towards a harder, slower development of character.

The Village's Silence: The Failed Expectation of Mob Punishment

Chandrapal thinks that if people abuse him he can fashion a story of persecution against himself. But the children keep their watch in silence. Their patience deprives him of his rehearsed dramatic defence. The scene avoids the violent confrontation he expects and constructs a public space in which listening can occur. Silence here is not emptiness but a condition of dialogue. The village's moral strength is revealed not in noise, but in the decision to offer neither immediate forgiveness nor revenge.

"Birth Name or Business Name?": The Drama of Identity

After hearing Chandrapal introduce himself, Ananya asks for his name at birth. When he says "Chandu", both names are entered together in the register. The act does not pardon his offence. It reveals the broken relationship between his mask of prestige and the person he was as a child. The social force of naming changes for a second time: after the restoration of victims' names, the accused too must face the name he has suppressed.

Meera's Resistance to Tears: The Difference Between Emotion and Truth

Chandrapal's eyes fill with tears, but Meera warns him that crying is not enough. With this single sentence, the story interrupts what could easily have become a theatre of repentance. The reader sees an emotional moment, but the narrative's ethical time does not end there. An incomplete admission, documented accounts, restitution and the names of accomplices still remain. The feeling of compassion and the demands of legal and social responsibility take different paths.

The Central Sentence of the Confession: The Wrong of Not Seeing Faces

Chandrapal says that he had not regarded people as people, but as a crowd on a screen; he made mourning into engagement and fear into a product. The absence of personal hatred does not, in his view, exempt him from wrongdoing: indifference meant abandoning the effort to see faces. This

admission is the character's first clear definition of himself. Within direct speech, commercial language hears its own criticism. The story does not declare the moment his final redemption.

Devika's Question About Accounts and the Return of Measurement

Devika asks how much was earned from Ujjwal's name. Chandrapal takes a sheet of accounts from his pocket. Devika does not immediately read it; she first insists upon distinguishing the dignity of the dead person's name from any sum of money. The need for paper is not rejected, but paper is not allowed to become synonymous with the name. Here private guilt acquires the direction of a documentary investigation. Significantly, the search for evidence becomes an event in the story: a question is asked, and the paper is produced.

The Collective Reception of Confession and the Absence of Pardon

The silence of those present gives the admission a public significance, but no one immediately speaks words of forgiveness. This arrangement of dialogue plays upon the reader's expectations: an emotional offender meeting a compassionate community might have yielded an easy conclusion. The author deliberately avoids that simple turn. By deferring resolution, the narrative keeps its moral question alive into the next chapter.

The Limited Sheet of Paper and the Larger Network It Suggests

Chandrapal's first account consists of only one sheet, not the whole financial web. He himself begins to recognise the need to disclose the names of associates and the routes of payment. A small object thus indicates an extended future narrative sequence. The reader has not been shown independent verification of the actual accounts; at this stage the sheet is merely preliminary material for gathering evidence. This limitation demands critical caution about the reliability of the confession.

The Message to Raghav and the Technological Impossibility

That night Chandrapal tries to tell his associate Raghav of the change, but only his message appears unable to connect. The fact that other phones continue to work sharpens the strangeness. Leaf-like writing on the screen becomes a warning that a code will not travel where a name must be heard. This technological failure is not presented as an impossible law of ordinary life; it functions as the story's ethical magic. A character's private admission is shown affecting the network of a global criminal enterprise.

Foreshadowing the Next Episode Concerning Raghav

The chapter ends at the threshold of Chandrapal's admission, without completing his inward punishment. The next instalment clearly promises the story of Raghav's isolation. The gradually awakening consciousness of one wrongdoer reaches the glass-walled room of another. In this sequence the novel keeps changing its character-centre without abandoning the shared watch over names or the image of the stump. Its serial dramatic structure draws the reader onward not merely through continuing mystery, but through shifting responsibility.

Critical Section 176 | Original Chapter 75 — Raghav: A Network Without a Signal

The Contradiction in the Title: A Signal but No Access

Raghav's phone displays full network bars and its data connection functions, yet his messages cannot reach their recipients. The central tension in the scene is the disparity between technical availability and social communication. Although the title speaks of a network without a signal, the equipment is fully operational; the meaning of "network" is therefore redefined within the story. Raghav's crisis is not about physical telecommunications but is a narrative metaphor for losing his secret control over information.

The Shadow Business of Disappearing Messages

Raghav has profited from incomplete truths, half-falsehoods, code names and disappearing messages. The narrator reconstructs his former expertise as a practice of language. The clarity of names and the obscurity of coded signals are placed in opposition. When messages cannot even be generated, Raghav loses his instruments and finds his social identity in crisis. His inward despair takes the form of an arrangement of scenes.

Four Failed Messages: The Network's Extent

Raghav tries in four directions to stop Batuknath's trust, halt Chandrapal's confession, warn Broom of the risk and inform Lau that names are spreading. All four attempts fail. The sequence of intended recipients forms a narrative map. It reveals the horizontal reach of the wrongdoing: different countries, institutions and centres of profit have remained connected through a single person. The failed communication exposes the weakness of that same network.

The Isolated Room and the Mechanical Echo of the City

Surrounded by soundproof walls, expensive curtains, filtered air and multiple phones, Raghav remains alone. The city's thousands of signals cannot lessen that solitude. The contradiction between material comfort and the absence of relationships forms his psychological landscape. The steady hum of the air conditioner becomes the buzzing of an enclosed vessel, increasing the tension. By reducing the noise outside, the narration heightens the intensity of the question within.

Roots in the Phone's Glass and Green Leaves Bearing Names

On a switched-off phone, an image appears of the felled stump and leaves bearing names. The gleaming digital surface acquires the rough texture of

bark. This sensory transformation brings the memory-site of a distant village into a man's hand in the city. The light of glass and the roots of the tree cease to be opposites: collective memory becomes an adversarial presence inside the digital world. The story makes this not a simple rejection of technology, but a question of who owns and controls it.

From Percentages to Promises in the Secret Paper Ledger

Raghav has believed that the private accounts he kept on paper were under his control. In the ledger, the word for "percentage" begins to become the word for "pledged". This phonetic transformation changes the division of profits into a promise of accountability. The story shows lines of written accounts altering, but independent verification of the actual financial records is still absent. Criticism must therefore read this marvel as a scene of moral change in language, not as a final financial settlement.

The Children's Rhythm of "Present"

In the Channa grove, Ananya and the children say "Present" in place of kabaddi's breathing rhythm. The narrator provides no mechanical evidence to establish whether this utterance affects Raghav's phone from afar. A shared village voice and the private screen in the city are placed alongside one another within the narration. Their juxtaposition reduces the emotional distance between places, while uncertainty about causation preserves the creative space of magical realism.

Self-Defensive Phrases Breaking Apart in an Empty Message

A blank message arrives from an unknown sender. Within that empty space Raghav hears his familiar excuses: merely a messenger, merely an adviser, not a share of profits but a fee. This is a literary use of absence. No charge is written down, yet the offender's own experience generates an accusation from within. The reader's perspective attaches itself to his internal focalisation. The blank screen is not a material ledger of evidence, but a surface on which conscience echoes.

The Automatic Reversal of a Reply: Language Gains Autonomy

Raghav wishes to ask who the sender is or to complain of intrusion, but the screen converts his questions into questions addressed to himself. The dialogue proceeds independently of what he wants. Through this device, the author separates the narrator's control of language from the character's. The man who habitually controlled the meaning of other people's messages can no longer claim authority over the meaning of his own words. The irony is especially sharp.

The Map of a "Network of Memory"

Before dawn, a line appears across all the phones, linking the river, bridge, hospital, stump, courtroom, app and room in the city. This new map is not an authentic digital survey of geography; it is a set of moral relationships emerging in the character's field of vision. By joining these sites on one thread, the author recalls scattered events from many earlier chapters. The metaphor of a network changes again: the secret routes of profit give way to the reciprocal obligations of memory.

The Disclosure of the Distant Name "Lau Kin-Hung"

Lau's name glows on the map. The image opens Raghav's hidden network towards an international character. Its narrative appeal lies not in discovering an "unknown foreigner", but in the courage to pronounce a name previously concealed. When Raghav speaks the full name without code, an inward obstruction gives way, although the criminal web has not been wholly exposed. The narrator preserves that incompleteness to make the next journey possible.

Relationships of Trust versus the Convenience of Signals

The old ghost says that truth requires relationships, not merely a network. This is a rule of dialogue within the story; treating it as a complete technical doctrine would mislead the reader. Trust raises difficult questions: with whom, after what injuries, and on what evidence? Raghav's loneliness intensifies them. A benevolent collective rhythm cannot by itself discharge the obligation to give an account.

Raghav's Inner Speech: Belated Self-Awareness

For the first time, without his phone, Raghav wonders what voice can be heard inside when no message goes through. The plot pauses at this point and the inward question carries the movement of the story. He receives no immediate answer; slowly he speaks Lau's full name. The regulation of pace matters: against the swift movement of devices stands the slowness of self-admission. A change in the character is suggested, not completed.

A Doorway to the Next Journey

At dawn, Ananya says that a distant name has stirred and that now a road, not a network, will open. The story makes a natural transition from Raghav's city room to Lau's journey between countries. The guarding of names in one place influences the position of a businessman elsewhere, although the means of that influence remain uncertain. By maintaining this uncertainty, the narrative lends curiosity to the wider, travelling geography of the next chapter.

Critical Section 177 | Original Chapter 76 — Lau Kin-Hung's Journey to India

The Narrative's Expansion from the Distant Sea to the Village

As soon as Raghav utters the name, the story shifts to a glass office on the twenty-second floor of a building in Hong Kong. This sudden enlargement of setting exposes the global economic connections of the local struggle at Garh Narikel. Ships, contracts, insurance, equipment, labour, organs and data are counted within the same commercial current. The rhythm of that enumeration itself imitates Lau's way of seeing. Yet the severed stump in the village emerges as an uncontrollable stain upon his map, constructing a counterpoint to his numerical outlook.

Screen Images and the Reversal of the Gaze

Lau watches images of the grove, name-stones, registers and Chandrapal on multiple screens. At first he takes them for material gathered through surveillance, but soon he feels that the images have turned around and are watching him. Narrative perspective moves here from the observer to the person observed. The man who possessed the screens of control now experiences himself as subject to another gaze. That reversal alters the balance of power between the metropolis and the village.

The Advisors' Three Proposals and the Class Divide in the Story

One advisor calls the resistance a passing emotion; another recommends using donations to buy the local institution; a third demands control over the digital archive. Although their language differs, all three seek proprietorship over memory. The author presents the characters' positions not in extended speeches but in a brief meeting. Economic power categorises the world for its own convenience, whereas resistance conducted in the names of people refuses to fit any single category. The narrative conflict therefore exceeds a simple opposition between philanthropy and protest.

The Dream of the Crocodile Chewing Through Contracts

Lau dreams of a river crocodile chewing not human bodies but contracts, appendices, secret accounts and reports. The animal of the novel's title is not merely a violent creature here; it becomes a counter-gaze that devours documentary secrecy. The crocodile asks him about the waters of his own name. The dream symbol carries the narrative from commercial property towards personal identity. It should be understood as the dream grammar of Lau's fear, not as an event established in external reality.

The Public and Private Purposes of the Journey

The journey's public justification is a review of rehabilitation investment; its private purpose is to investigate the failures of Chandrapal and Raghav; its inward impulse is a compulsion to stand in the Channa grove. The narrator distinguishes Lau's declared objective from his unspoken motivation. This threefold construction of causality makes him more complex than a one-dimensional commercial villain, without diminishing his responsibility for an exploitative network. The journey is simultaneously an act of strategy and an event within an unsettled conscience.

The Harbour of Childhood Memory and an Old Scene of Debt

On the aircraft Lau remembers a small harbour, his father's shop, the smell of fish and backs bent under debt. His present financial empire is connected to an experience of humiliation in childhood. This retrospection reveals the fractured moral relationship between a desire for social ascent and the practice of erasing other people's names. Memory illuminates the first motives of his business, but the narrator does not infer that being a victim once makes him innocent now.

The Aircraft's Altitude and the Surviving Voice Below

At first the aircraft's ascent above the earth offers Lau a momentary sense of release through distance. Yet the rhythm of kabaddi reaches his ears among the clouds. Sound cancels the seeming advantage of altitude and national boundaries. Both the lofty floor of the glass office and the aircraft in the sky visualise attempts to remain distant from the suffering of others. The kabaddi rhythm cuts across that distance. This continuing acoustic motif joins the chapter to the preceding village narrative.

The Elderly Passenger with a Newspaper: The Force of a Brief Exchange

An elderly Indian passenger reading a Maithili newspaper shows Lau a photograph of the festival of names. Lau cannot understand the language, but recognises the children. The older man asks where memory will remain when the server shuts down, challenging claims made for the permanence of digital archives. The force of the exchange lies in its refusal to present anyone's entire ideology. One photograph, an unfamiliar script and a single question disturb the foreign character's comfortable assumptions.

Script and the Unequal Positions of Translation

To Lau, Maithili letters resemble ripples on water; their meanings are not immediately available to him. The distance between the elderly traveller's mother tongue and Lau's international language of commerce creates a need for translation within the narrative. Not understanding is not, in itself, a weakness; the powerful man who does not know the language of local names must nonetheless enter a world beyond the language of profit. By watching the photograph, hearing the words and waiting for meaning, the reader participates in this encounter between differing linguistic experiences.

A Second Dream: The Inner Passageways of the Stump

Lau falls asleep again on the aircraft and walks along the circular paths within the stump. Behind each ring lies an arrangement of scenes from lives marked by exclusion. A figure identified as Gangesha asking questions brings further complexity to Lau's conscience, although the concern of this criticism is the dream's imaginative construction. The tiny leaves of a book and the numbers in a ledger confront one another as visible images. The dream does not establish additional historical claims about a biography.

Watercourses on Indian Soil: A New View of Geography

Seen through gaps in the clouds, the network of rivers makes India appear to Lau not merely as a market but as a long continuity of memory. This moment also raises the danger of giving an immense country a simplistic cultural uniformity: the names are bound to differing castes, forms of labour, river landings, exclusions and stories. Lau's abruptly altered vision is his own experience, not an omniscient explanation of society as a whole. The criticism retains this limit of focalisation.

The Passport Stamp versus Actual Entry

A border official stamps Lau's passport, but Lau realises that he still has to face the questions of the children of Garh Narikel. A clear distinction arises between legal entry and ethical presence. Crossing a state border is necessary in this story, but not sufficient. The difference between recognition on paper and questioning by a community's memory gives an international form to the novel's continuing conflict over records.

The Crocodile's Reflection at the Airport

A crocodile's eye reflected in glass does not consume Lau; it simply watches him. Here the dread of being seen is sharper than the fear of violence. Glass, earlier the comfort of his office, now becomes the site of a crisis of transparency. In the dream the crocodile chewed contracts; in waking glass

it assumes the form of a wordless gaze. The returning image binds the story's geographical expansion within one chain of symbols.

Straight to Garh Narikel: The Planned Journey Breaks Down

Disregarding his associate's request for a meeting in the capital, Lau orders an immediate departure for the village. The long international journey is concentrated into a small decisive act. The interpreter's surprise marks the disruption of Lau's programme. Yet this apparent completion of the journey is followed in the next chapter by an extended repetition of his arrival. Chapter 76's final entry must therefore be read alongside the beginning of Chapter 77 rather than assumed to settle the chronology.

Critical Section 178 | Original Chapter 77 — The Crocodile at the Airport

The Restart of the Arrival and a Problem of Chronology

At the end of Chapter 76, Lau steps off the aircraft and tells his interpreter to travel directly to Garh Narikel. Chapter 77 then narrates at length another sequence of the aircraft landing, the arrivals queue, the journey to the hotel and the decision to proceed. This may be a retelling of the same time span, but the text supplies no explicit signal of retrospection. Reading it literally as events on the following day therefore produces a chronological inconsistency. Criticism must leave open both possibilities: purposeful narrative repetition and an editorial lapse.

The Persistent Image of the Eye and the Insecure Observer

The crocodile's eye that flashed in the glass in Chapter 76 follows Lau in this chapter through a facial-recognition machine, railings, shop windows and the hotel. The objects change, but the sign of the gaze remains constant. By repeating a single image across many reflective surfaces, the author produces a narrative enclosure. Lau, who previously subjected others to surveillance, is now beset by the gaze of apparently every object. This is the psychological rhythm of his passage through the city.

The Strange Flicker at the Border-Control Machine

For an instant, a crocodile's eye appears in place of Lau's face at a digital entry gate; the official takes it to be an ordinary technical fault. The narrative places Lau's private experience and the official's unremarkable reaction within the same moment. Their contrasting experiences of one machine expose the limits of narrative certainty. The reader cannot establish whether the eye appeared objectively on the screen or was an observation shaped by Lau's guilt.

A Sequence of Smells: The Breaking of Class Distance

The smells of spices, diesel, sweat, dampness and earth interrupt Lau's air-conditioned experience. The story does not confine a foreign character's entry into India to identity documents and diplomatic appearances; it fills the scene with the direct experience of the body. Later, the cool air and marble of a five-star hotel attempt to hold those first sensations at bay. This opposition of sensory worlds pierces what seemed an impenetrable protective enclosure of capital.

The Advertisement for an "Unnamed Planet" and the Irony of the Future

An airport billboard promises a secure future beyond Earth. Lau relates it to his investment interests, but the crocodile's eye returns in the glass. The novel thus stretches its narrative reach from erased village names to an extraterrestrial future without names. Earth's unfinished justice stands against the advertisement's apparently limitless possibilities. This speculative future is not yet a fully described real project, but an indication of the character's economic imagination.

Messages from Three Accomplices and the Tension with Earlier Admissions

In the guest room, messages from Batuknath, Chandrapal and Raghav appear to propose renewed control over memory. But Chandrapal has already confessed in Chapter 74, while Chapter 75 showed Raghav's communications failing to get through. The messages carry no clear dates here. They may be old messages reread; otherwise there is an inconsistency in character development and chronology. The criticism records this collision without inventing an arbitrary sequence of events to resolve it.

A River Appearing in a Glass of Water

Lau perceives a dense green movement of the river within water supplied as a clean, bottled commodity. The memory of earlier waters returns inside water reduced to a commercial product. The reader receives no final explanation of the transformation; through Lau's experience the narrator presents the instability of memory attached to place. This minute scene brings a discussion of lofty global projects back to local questions of labour, the river and unnamed bodies.

The Elderly Cleaner Missing from the List

In the guest room an elderly cleaner tells Lau to drink water and think about names, yet no trace of the cleaner appears in staff records, the entry register or security-camera footage. Within the story this is a threefold failure of systems that record identity. The unnamed person is not merely absent: they have spoken directly to Lau. Ghost, memory or ordinary delusion—the narrator commits to none of these classifications. This openness intensifies both the character's fear and the reader's ethical alertness.

Documentary Absence and Experienced Presence

Although the security systems retain no record of the cleaner, a ripple remains in the glass of water. The scene repeats the novel's central figure

between memorial name-stones and digital entry registers: a written list cannot contain the whole of a human life. This criticism reads the incident not as a report documenting a genuine security failure, but as the literary reappearance of a worker erased from society. The cleaner is given the right to speak, though the risk remains that this person will be confined to a mere mystery.

Bridges and Drains Reappear in the Urban Landscape

From the car window, shopping malls, shanties, the metro, structures under construction and open drains move together across Lau's field of vision. In every drain he sees a river's shadow; under every bridge, the memory of vanished workers. The city's architecture is suddenly linked to the violence of the village narrative. This juxtaposition does not permit the harm caused by global projects to remain detached from everyday urban travel. The arrangement of sights strengthens the chapter's realist foundation.

The Crocodile's Shadow in the Hotel Room

The cool marble of the shining hotel offers Lau the semblance of a safe place in which to forget. But the shadow of a crocodile appears at the window, facing him. Once more the objects of a private room become screens for guilt. Neither glass nor curtains can maintain a secure personal boundary. By letting the consequences of a public struggle enter the character's sleep, the novel enlarges psychological time.

The Dream Passport and the Ledger of Profit

In a dream, children sit in the places of officials at an ordinary arrivals checkpoint. A profit-and-loss ledger replaces the passport, and a crocodile chews its pages. In this variation on Chapter 76's river dream, the formalities of international passage become a test of one's presence before community memory. Lau must confront the question of his real name. Although the image recurs, the pressure grows because the question is now posed at a boundary inside India.

An Anonymous Invitation to the Waiting Room

A message at dawn summons Lau to the empty waiting room on the old airport road. It has no sender's name, only a call to listen. The message will not disappear: it returns on the telephone, in the glass and as an inward voice. Through this device, listening becomes an opposing ethical demand rather than an ordinary meeting. Yet in the following chapter the actual place of the encounter is named as the Channa grove. This chapter supplies no explicit intermediate link accounting for the change of venue.

Preparing for Satyavrat's Entrance

At the chapter's close, Lau understands that he is to meet Satyavrat, a listener unimpressed by wealth or rank. This prepares the drama of the next silent dialogue. The crocodile strips away not Lau's flesh but the first skin of his sense of safety: the image redirects the fear of bodily injury towards self-examination. Despite the uncertainty of time and place, the coming question is clear: who has the authority to determine the terms of listening—economic power or those who guard the names?

Critical Section 179 | Original Chapter 78 — Satyavrat and Lau's Silent Dialogue

From the Waiting Room to the Stump: An Unwritten Change of Venue

In the previous chapter, Lau was summoned to an empty waiting room on the old airport road. The opening of this chapter says the message's route led directly to the Channa grove, and Satyavrat establishes the stump as their meeting place. Such a redirection is possible, but the intermediary actions of the journey are not elaborated. From a critical perspective, the shift of setting can be understood either as economical narration or as an incomplete narrative bridge. Ignoring the discrepancy and declaring the sequence wholly linear would go beyond what the original text establishes.

Abandoning the Official Meeting and Insisting on a "Place of Names"

Lau declines the press, an investors' dinner and formal meetings. Satyavrat, too, refuses to choose an office in Delhi; he makes the public space by the stump necessary for their encounter. This choice redistributes narrative power. The representative of capital leaves the familiar ease of an office to enter the communal space of those harmed. The reversal of roles is established without slogans, merely by changing where the participants must sit.

Satyavrat's Seat Outside the Circle

Satyavrat does not sit at the centre among the name-stones; he sits to one side, with a register and an old shoulder-bag. The arrangement has formal significance: he does not make himself the leader or owner of popular memory, but a listener. After his brief invitation to sit, his prolonged silence postpones the question-and-answer exchange Lau anticipates. Satyavrat's earlier practice of another kind of silence here acquires a practical location within the story.

The Recitation of Names and the Slowing of Time

During the first ten names Lau simply listens; between the eleventh and fourteenth, boardroom tables and the vocabulary of costs begin to return to his mind. The successive enumeration of names slows the story's experienced time. The tension of the silent dialogue emerges within this delay. Lau is accustomed to counting numbers, but begins to recognise a distinct life in every name; the meaning of the very act of counting changes dramatically.

The Response "Present": The Social Return of the Dead

Children call out names and the gathering answers, "Present." This collective response affirms the social presence of people absent from administrative attendance lists. Repetition gives the chapter a lyrical rhythm. Yet the narrator offers no evidence of a literal return to life after death: this is an act of storytelling that restores memory, testimony and relations within the community. The scene therefore points towards collective responsibility without exaggerating remembrance into miraculous physical resurrection.

Names Rather Than Accusations: Reversing the Structure of Dialogue

Lau expects direct accusations, but Satyavrat says that names are read here. The language of the dispute changes. Instead of an immediate exchange of charges and defences, the scene introduces the slower process of listening. The question of culpability is not erased in this silence; its temporal priority is altered. By avoiding a scene of direct confrontation, the author creates a different, more demanding drama of ethical responsibility.

How One Listener Changes Another's Gaze

Satyavrat seldom looks directly at Lau for long; he listens instead. Through this conduct, Lau begins to recognise the inadequacy of his company's language. The presence of a listener gradually draws even the opposing man into the act of listening. This reversal of perspective is produced not by one individual's speech but by the shared occasion of reading names. The narrative method connects character development to time experienced together rather than to the instant impact of an address.

Names Across Scripts: An Experiment in Dual Records

Ananya gives Lau charcoal and permits him to write a name in his own script, while recording its Devanagari pronunciation alongside it. This remarkable small scene suggests the possibility of multilingual memory. The local community does not erase the foreign man's name; it assumes public responsibility for its pronunciation. The coexistence of scripts on one stone does not establish effortless cultural equality. It establishes a new relationship subject to the demanding condition of presence.

The Guilty Person's Presence and the Distance from Forgiveness

Satyavrat makes clear that writing Lau's name is not forgiveness, only the first stage of being present. The statement recalls the incompleteness of Chandrapal's earlier confession. What becomes visible within the story is not a mechanism of punishment but an ethical sequence: first appear in person; then hear the names of those harmed; then give an account. The

magical sensation of the stone's weight intensifies inner unease, but leaves the concrete work of accountability undone.

The Suspension of a Donation Pledge and Batuknath's Response

Lau suspends a proposed donation because he must first listen to the names. On hearing the news, Batuknath's initial easy smile hardens, for the financial basis of his trust has become uncertain. The scene unfolds across two places: the silence by the stump and a distant advisory office. The conflict of interests is clear without a direct encounter. A character's personal inquiry is beginning to affect an institutionally managed economy.

An Old Schoolroom: An Uncertain Respite from Luxury

The children do not allow Lau to stay inside the stump's enclosure; he is given accommodation in a school outside the village. A faltering fan, crumbling limewash, the calls of frogs and the rustle of coarse khadi are far removed from his luxurious surroundings. Bodily discomfort becomes a narrative lesson, but the passage does not glorify poverty. The character seeking exemption from the demands of security is given the chance to spend one night alongside the history of a place.

A Faceless Future in the Dream of an "Unnamed Planet"

In Lau's dream, figures appear beneath a shining dome, but there are no human names. The stump from the Channa grove grows up amid that lifeless future, and at the children's touch contracts fall from Lau's pocket. This future world is, in narrative terms, an imagined vision rather than a scientific fact. The inward dream develops the speculation suggested by the advertisement in Chapter 77. It reveals the impossibility of selling a future detached from the exploitation of the past.

The Sequence of Three Days and the Discipline of Patience

The children's rule—first listening, then names, then documents—creates a sequential order of time. For Lau, accustomed to quick donations and deals, such slowness is almost unbearable. The narrator presents this suspended time as an effective form of punishment. Criticism must also acknowledge, however, that the complete practical framework for observing the rule is only sketched at this point; the story has not yet shown it to be a fully established administrative system.

The Arrival of Broom's Envoy: From Silence to a Conflict Over Documents

At the chapter's close, an envoy arrives with a deed of donation edged in gold. Neither Lau nor Satyavrat smiles; Ananya places an empty stone in

readiness to ask whose name the donation bears. The drama of passive waiting ends, opening a public scene in which a document will be read. A rustling sound rises from the stump in the Channa grove—the audible announcement of the next critical section.

Critical Section 180 | Original Chapter 79 — Broom's Deed of Donation

The Arrival of the Deed of Donation and Its Glossy Surface

On the morning after Lau's silent dialogue, a postal packet reaches the village, edged in gold, inscribed in a mixture of scripts, and made of thick paper. The object's appearance draws the reader's attention from the very beginning of the narrative. Its polished seal looks like a sign of institutional legitimacy, yet the shadow of the old contract falls across the document's heading. The conflict between outward splendour and the purpose concealed within it becomes the chapter's principal movement of events.

An Old Company's New Fund: The Disguised Story of Renaming

The former name of Broom's organisation has disappeared; its new name, the "World Memory Restoration Fund," announces the protection of memory. The narrator immediately recalls the earlier network of bridge foundations, labourers' losses, water, medicine, and data. Within the narrative, the relationship between the new institution's language and the old contracts thus becomes a question. This criticism does not rest on an independently documented external history of the company but on the recurrence of events already constructed within the novel.

The Enthusiastic Voice of Development and the Absence of the Dead

A municipal official and local supporters envisage a memorial, employment, and the possibility of international recognition. Although the "name of Garh Narikel" is repeatedly invoked, the personal names of the unidentified dead are not. Through this opposition, the narrative develops a critique of the rhetoric of development. The author does not simply label the supporters villains; he also depicts the village's genuine lack of basic amenities. The dispute is consequently more complex than an immediate choice between accepting and rejecting the donation.

The Representative's Rehearsed Maithili and Performative Compassion

The representative speaks in rehearsed Maithili of a donation made without self-interest. A glittering vocabulary of "compassion" accompanies the list of an international-standard museum and research rooms. A sound like insects gnawing inside the stump seems to edit that word. The collision between the character's linguistic performance and the sound of the place produces irony. The scene does not condemn an

outsider's language as such; it makes the rhetoric of compassion without accountability appear untrustworthy.

Devika and Meera's Questions: The Theatre of Consent

Devika asks what will be taken in exchange for the gift; Meera enumerates, one by one, photographs, privacy, the use of stories, copies of records, and families' permission. After the representative answers "nothing," his admission that operational conditions apply opens a crack in his statement. The dialogue's step-by-step progression matters: the mask of the elegant proposal does not fall after a single question, but through sustained questioning. The narrative issue is the possibility that rights may be transferred under the language of sharing resources.

Ananya's Question About Signatures and Community Rights

The deed includes a clause placing the interpretation and rights of use of memorial materials under the fund's control. The representative calls the "community" the owner, but Ananya asks for the community's signatures. Her question clarifies the difference between collectively invoking a name and obtaining the actual consent of those who own the material. Rather than converting the exchange into a modern legal exposition, one must attend to how, in the original text, a girl sets the document's formal pronoun against the consent of real persons.

Arun's Bridge Contract: The Narrative's Outstanding Debt

Arun brings forward the old discrepancy between the written safeguards for workers and the injuries actually suffered. The representative attempts to dismiss it as a separate contract. In this confrontation, the past returns to the centre of the present scene. The proposed memory centre is not allowed to stand apart from those who died on the bridge. The novel's extended narrative time is compressed here into a dense exchange: the earlier harm becomes an inseparable question for the new donation project.

Ba's Sense of Smell and an Embodied Counter-Narrative

Ba smells the paper and says it carries the odour of a closed room. The sense of smell is not authenticated here as an instrument for reaching legal conclusions; it is a sensory expression of communal memory. The children enter her remark in their register. Throughout the novel, the poetic language of bodily experience returns to challenge the formally correct words written on paper. The scene reveals cooperation between the older generation's memory of hearing and sensing and the younger generation's work of documentation.

The Poor Village's Needs and the Complexity of the Donation Dispute

The narrative itself acknowledges that saving the memorial and its records requires money, roads, shelter, and preservation. The local proposal —"Take the money now; we can amend the conditions later"—expresses a real dilemma. Meera explains how difficult it becomes to enforce later restrictions once the rights have been granted in the opening clauses. Through this conflict, the chapter avoids becoming a flat story against money; it depicts a difficult social choice among necessity, control, and dignity.

Gop's Reading of the Fine Print

Gop Kumar detects a clause granting the fund first rights of use over jointly produced communication materials. The plot comes to rest on this fine print. The small condition tells a story opposite to that proclaimed by the golden heading. This close scene of reading a document raises the possibility of future control over photographs, voices, images, and stories associated with the named dead. One short passage in the written terms changes the meaning of the entire performance of giving.

Raindrops and the Dissolution of the Deed's Form

A heavy raindrop suddenly falls upon the deed's seal, and its sheen begins to fade. Beneath it, clauses concerning workers' accommodation, safety, medical treatment, and compensation emerge on an old blue sheet. This is a magical scene of physical transformation within the story, not a claim that ordinary paper changes itself in this way in the external world. Water becomes an active agent of memory. The body of the deed is revealed to have served as a covering for an earlier offence.

Permission to Make an Image: From Spectacle to Community Archive

Devika lifts her device to photograph the wet deed, but Meera asks her first to secure permission from the affected families. The photograph is taken only after permission is obtained. This act is set against the journalist's camera in an earlier chapter and Chandrapal's secret audio recordings. The instrument may remain the same, but the ethical circumstances of its purpose have changed. An image is neither an offence nor a means of liberation in itself; its narrative meaning depends on consent and use.

Visual Evidence and the Critical Limits of Mystery

The people present see the lettering of the old contract emerge after the rain, but the representative takes the deed away. What remains in the reader's hands is not an independently examinable physical document, but

a narrated scene and an account of the community's effort to photograph it. The narrative thus exposes the background of wrongdoing by means of a marvel; literary criticism should not issue a certificate of legal proof on the strength of this scene. The blending of realism and magical realism recalls social injury and raises fresh questions.

Batuknath's Son's Question and the Final Sign of the Wet Envelope

In the latter part of the chapter, Batuknath's son reads the papers of the People's Memory Trust at home and asks whether its purpose is to safeguard justice or a profession. One question from the son draws the chain of culpability from the dream court into the intimacy of family relationships. It is a clear seed for the next chapter, "Hariharan's Children." The question of inheritance within a family cannot be separated from criminal contracts or the dispute over the gift: will the inheritor of prestige become a witness to wrongdoing? The narrative pauses at this unresolved choice. The representative takes away the original sheets of the deed, but the children place the empty, wet envelope near the stump. The emptied frame of a documentary object becomes the section's final symbol. Those present do not pronounce the donation merely a victory or defeat; they declare that its conditions regarding rights must be examined. The stains of water remaining wet until night mark the long duration of narrative memory. This ending does not close the event; it opens the next generation's question.

Critical Section 181 | Original Chapter 80 — Hariharan's Children

The Transition from the Wet Deed to the Household Threshold

At the close of the preceding chapter, rainwater on Broom's deed of donation revealed the language of the old contract. The narrative then leaves the public contest in the office and moves to Batuknath's private veranda. The reverberation of the exposed external contract is transformed into a child's question within the home. This connection relies less on a rigid mechanical sequence of cause and effect than on an association between objects and questions. The debate about justice consequently passes from the public arena into the inheritance of a family.

The Architecture of the Veranda and the Weakening of Authority

The portraits of ancestors, books of law, certificates of honour, glass-fronted cupboard, and motionless fan form a visible inventory of Batuknath's prestige. No official court hearing is taking place here; nevertheless, its objects turn the domestic veranda into an imitation courtroom. The narrator displays the arrangement of things before revealing the weary man among them. This reversed emphasis lets the reader see that an institutional aura can no longer sustain the character's moral strength.

Tarini's Entrance: An Independent Voice of Questioning

Tarini is studying law; her opposition to her father's habit of treating law as professional manoeuvring is marked from the outset. She has watched the events at the Channa grove on her phone, but she switches off the screen before beginning to question him at home. This small action establishes a distinction between mediated experience and face-to-face conversation. Tarini emerges not merely as the author's mouthpiece, but as an independent speaking presence, shaped by the particular discomfort of a father–daughter relationship.

The Recurring Question: Justice or a Profession?

"Did you protect justice, or your profession?" This question is the chapter's central axis. In a single utterance, Tarini links the workers' bridge, Ujjwal's fraud, Meera's privacy, and the People's Memory Trust. Previously dispersed fields of wrongdoing enter the home as one dramatic accusation. The summary of events recalls earlier sequences for the reader, but this recapitulation becomes critical recollection through the technique of collage; it is not an imaginary addition of new events.

The Divided Face and Limited Focalisation

In the glass, Batuknath sees two versions of his own face: the publicly honoured lawyer and the man who has woven a web of procedure. The perspective is centred on his experience, so the reflection in the glass is a scene of moral self-examination, not external evidence. Tarini's words provide a counterpoint to his inward vision. By presenting the same scene through inner trembling and an outward question, the narrative allows the reader to comprehend the character's insecurity without thereby reducing his culpability.

The Narrative Use of Biographical Memory of Gangesha

References to the folklore surrounding Gangesha's birth, the circumstances of his marriage, and his scholarly standing occur in the dialogue as part of a dispute over the politics of memory. Tarini asks why the public language of honour suppresses uncomfortable accounts of a life. These references should be treated in criticism as dialogue within the novel and as expressions of the characters' viewpoints. Historical allegations voiced within a story cannot, without independent verification, be presented as established history. The object of analysis is the dialogue's force and its arrangement.

The Temporal Construction of Delay and the Victims' Time

In Batuknath's legal practice, repeated hearing dates, adjournments, and technical objections have consumed years of the victims' lives. Calling this the "punishment of listening," Tarini turns that delay back upon Batuknath. The narrative effects an ethical reversal of narrative time: the man who imposed waiting on others must now endure the prolonged obligation to listen. This is more than a feeling of remorse; it is a dramatic indication that control over time may change hands.

The Domestic Reappearance of the Dream Court

During the family conversation, the veranda floor becomes a stump, the pages of books turn into leaves and fly away, and an empty childhood slipper appears upon the seat of judgement. Images from the earlier dream court return in a new location. Here, however, an absent child's bodily trace occupies the judge's place. The magical transformation intensifies the private discussion; the narrator does not establish that all the characters perceive the altered scene in the same way.

Collective Images of Inheritance

Behind Tarini appear the shadows of children from families implicated in several networks of wrongdoing. A question arising in one family expands into a long dispute over inheritance among many families. This is not a

literal assembly, but an enlargement of the field of Batuknath's fear and his vision of the future. The children open up the possibility of refusing an inheritance of wealth, surnames, prestige, and lies. The narrative's centre shifts away from a culpable man's claim to reform and towards the autonomous decisions of the next generation.

The Wrongdoer and the Father: The Duality of an Ethical Relationship

Tarini does not relinquish her right to love her father, but she refuses to inherit his silence. This distinction prevents the scene from becoming either a simple rebellion against a father or a story that ends with forgiveness. Alongside her accusation, the daughter leaves some space for their relationship; the father is not suddenly declared innocent. The scene's realist force lies in that unresolved bond. Affection within a family is no compensation for harm done in public life, but it can be a place where demanding questions are asked.

From the Chairmanship of the Trust to Public Vigilance

Batuknath had previously planned to keep the People's Memory Trust under his own control. Tarini urges that its administration be handed to the children, workers' families, the women's assembly, and the guardians of names. The statement is an explicit proposal to alter relations of power, but no institution has yet actually been transferred. The novel preserves the distance between aspiration and implementation; criticism cannot take a declaration of change for a completed reform.

The Crossed-Out Word "Adjourned": Rewriting a Document

In the morning, Batuknath writes "Adjourned" on his proposal, crosses it out, and writes instead, "To be heard before the people's watchdogs." The small verbal revision is visually momentous. The first formulation expresses an old prerogative to halt time; the second acknowledges the right of people outside his control to be heard. This line on paper is not complete proof of institutional restructuring, but it is a measured dramatic act performed by the character's own hand. Writing after the dream becomes the narrative's tangible outcome.

An Ending Without an Embrace: Incomplete Reformation

At the end, Tarini does not stage a dramatic reconciliation with her father. As she removes a garland from a certificate of honour, her words remain firmly on the side of questioning. This pause safeguards the narrative's ethical seriousness: prolonged injustice does not end with one night of tearful conversation. Batuknath's ageing body and the opening

dawn generate opposing experiences of time. The time remaining to live has diminished, while the time of accountability has newly opened.

The Inconsistency Between the Son and Daughter References

At the end of Chapter 79, a "son" is shown picking up the paper and asking a question. In Chapter 80, that same narrative question is developed in the voice of Tarini, a daughter studying law. The title "Children" leaves the distinction open, but no indication of identity bridges the earlier "son" and the explicitly named Tarini who follows. This redistribution could be read as a literary recentring of the narrative, yet it also creates an inconsistency in textual continuity. Criticism cannot invent a definitive resolution to this discrepancy in the original text.

Critical Section 182 | Original Chapter 81 — Batra's Incomplete Name

The Bounds of the White Page: A Stage for Self-Identification

The chapter cuts away from Batuknath's family to Chandrapal's solitary room. On a white sheet of paper are the words "Write your own name"; the identity of whoever issued the command remains uncertain. The narrative turns this ordinary sheet into a small stage on which a signature is not a confirmation of property or office but a crisis of self-identification. The quiet room and the emptiness of the page powerfully counter the heavy curtain of the network of wrongdoing.

Titles and Profit Shares: The Replacement of a Name

Chandrapal has worked under numerous designations, including director, adviser, representative, and technical partner. Yet when he tries to sign his own name, the words "ten per cent," "half the profit," and "commission" appear. This magical substitution of words is effective because the vocabulary of profit has appropriated the character's account of himself. The scene depicts not ordinary forgetfulness but the displacement of personhood by commercial designations. Repeated failures to write establish the rhythm of the narrative.

The Pen's Defiance and the Instability of Vision

Chandrapal cannot set down the name he intends to write; he feels that an unseen clerk inside him is compiling a list of profits. The narrator opens the scene through Chandrapal's perception. The reader cannot know with certainty whether the paper is actually changing or guilt is changing what the character sees. Keeping both possibilities of magical realism open increases the reader's active participation.

The Memory of a Name Spoken by His Mother

The childhood home, an old writing slate, his mother's and father's voices, and a promise of light gradually emerge from beneath the company's figures. The character's narrative time descends from his present failure to write into an unclouded past. The short name his mother used is no evidence of innocence, merely a living fragment of memory. This flashback lets the reader see the offender's humanity without erasing the account of the harm suffered by his victims.

"Chandu" and "Channu": A Variant in the Text of the Name

In Chapter 74, Chandrapal told Ananya that his birth name was "Chandu"; in the present chapter, his mother's call is given as "Channu."

Both forms could be affectionate domestic names, but the original text provides no explanation of the difference. When the smallest detail of a name's pronunciation forms the basis of the plot, this variant becomes a meaningful editorial question. The review does not silently replace one form with the other.

The Degree from Meerut and the Old Language of Defence

Chandrapal recalls his degree from Meerut and the prestige of his business; an unheard voice within asks whose protection his education and enterprise actually served. The movement of question and answer lends dramatic tension to his motionless body at the desk. The arguments that he had offered to others for decades now reappear as a counterargument within his own mind. This inward dialogue is a major device of interior narration.

The Hidden Layer of the Memorial Application

In an older copy of the application, Devika sees, behind the names, the shadow of financial shares attached to donations, messages, and tributes. The public-facing display and the concealed earnings are divided into two layers of a single screen. The assertion that absent families profit from the memory of the dead is an allegation within the narrative; the scene does not provide complete evidence from actual accounts. Devika's statement is an interpretation grounded in what she has observed, and its verification remains dependent on subsequent documentary procedures.

Simultaneity at a Distance: The Register Writing by Itself

Chandrapal writes "percentage" in his room while, in the same narrative moment, the word "percentage" appears in a register at the distant Channa grove. The narrator breaks across spatial limits to make two scenes simultaneous. This extraordinary parallel editing strengthens the connection between a distant network of wrongdoing and the local network of memory, yet it does not determine the actual means by which the information travelled.

Ba and the Difficult Question of Recording an Offender's Name

The children ask why an offender's name should be kept in the archive of memory. Ba replies that the name of wrongdoing is recorded not for forgiveness, but for the archive. This is an important limit within a narrative of justice: even while victims remain central, the offender's identity must not be made to disappear. Satyavrat adds the question of preventing responsibility from being evaded again. The scene depicts not the consensus of an assembly but an education in difficult listening.

"Ch…": The Final Form of Incomplete Writing

After repeated attempts, neither the whole of "Channu" nor "Chandrapal" appears on the page. Only "Ch…" remains, with "percentage" beneath it. The narrative does not solve the problem; it fixes it in a visible form. The proportion between the first letter of a name and the fully written word for profit displays the character's ethical imbalance. This incompleteness prepares the symbol of the inner elephant-and-crocodile struggle in the following chapter.

The Difference Between the Folk Song and the Story's Final Signature

In the folk song at the chapter's end, a line suggests that writing "Chandrapal" makes "Batra" falter; on the final white page of the principal narrative, however, only "Ch…" survives. These different layers of the text allow the name to be written to different extents. The song may offer a metaphorical compression, but it remains distinct from the precise state of the image in the narrative scene. Analysis should not treat the song's readily grasped summary as a word-for-word reproduction of the principal scene.

A Paper Leaf and an Elephant's Eye in the Glass

At the end, the paper folds itself into the form of a leaf, and Chandrapal sees an elephant's eye, rather than his own face, in the glass, with the jaws of a crocodile behind it. This chain of objects—the leaf, the glass, the eye—gives private guilt the form of an animal narrative. The transformation is not an ordinary visual occurrence but an anticipation of the next chapter's title; it prepares to make the conflict within the character visible.

The Distance Between Guilt, Weeping, and Restitution

Chandrapal weeps, but the stump remains silent. In that silence, the plot does not grant automatic forgiveness; the distance between an offender's unsettled self-reflection and the victims' actual rights remains intact. The scene thus avoids a potentially sentimental collapse. If the reader were to treat the character's tears as final justice, the accounting of donations, fraud, and the application would be obscured. The text itself resists this shortcut.

The Limits of the Coming Elephant-and-Crocodile Contest

Ananya announces that the next scene will be the "Elephant and Crocodile Within." The movement from paper to leaf, leaf to eye, and eye to a water creature directly bridges the chapters. It awakens the expectation that the images of the earlier stories will no longer remain confined to one character's room but will become an inner structure shared by several

offenders and witnesses. This ending displaces the "incomplete signature" into the next collective metaphor.

The Opening Folk Song's Premature Shift of Subject

The chapter's opening song, "Clean the Pond Within," draws upon the hopeful rhythm of the elephant-and-crocodile image, while its main narrative concentrates on Chandrapal's inability to sign his name. The song announces in advance the object-metaphor of the coming Chapter 82. It may be read as deliberate foreshadowing. Nevertheless, given the tendency of opening songs in successive chapters to correspond to the following chapter's subject, the possibility of editorial displacement also requires examination.

Critical Section 183 | Original Chapter 82 — The Elephant and Crocodile Within

One Pond, Many Banks: Structural Convergence

Hariharan's children, Batra's unfinished name, Raghav's broken messages, and Lau's vision of a crocodile in the glass—previously separate trajectories of characters—come together in this chapter as "the four banks of one pond." The narrator establishes a metaphorical coexistence without arranging an actual social meeting among them. In this "pond within," geographical distances are transformed into a shared structure of mental conflict. The mythological allusion to the elephant and crocodile is not itself an event in the plot; it is a means of making several antagonisms into one visible map.

A Collective Vision at Night and Its Narrative Level

Darkness deepens around the severed stump, and the children witness the inner struggles of several people. This is difficult to regard as an ordinary scene witnessed by external spectators: it takes the form of a collective imagining or a magical enactment. The narrator changes the scenes as though the minds of different performers were being opened, one after another, upon a single screen. A distinctive feature of this narrative level is that a person, even when alone, becomes part of a collective interpretation.

Elephant and Crocodile: The Duality of Conflict Within the Person

The elephant represents a person's suppressed truth; the crocodile represents the grip of greed, caste, professional deceit, coded silence, and anonymous profit. The symbols do not end in an easy division between an inward good and an outward evil. The crocodile has also been formed within the character's own life; people have fed it through their practices. The critical force of the metaphor lies in this internal coexistence. Consequently, wrongdoing cannot be eliminated simply by destroying a single enemy.

Batuknath's Childhood and the Jaws of Procedure

The first vision begins with Hariharan's black coat and white bands, but inside his chest the trunk of an imprisoned elephant tries to emerge. An episode from his childhood, involving free assistance to an impoverished client, figures an earlier possibility within him. The crocodile is composed of hearing dates, fees, caste pride, and stratagems for defending the guilty. The repetition of Tarini's question brings back the mental conflict of the preceding chapter; this time, however, it appears not as a conventional account but as a bodily confrontation.

The Child Writing a Name Inside Chandrapal

Chandrapal's elephant is a small child writing "Chandra" upon the earth. The crocodile changes that writing into "percentage," "broker," and "wallet." These substitutions give new density, on another stage, to the image of the disobedient pen in Chapter 81. The recurrence is not merely a weakness in the narration but a progressive enlargement of the image: first an unsuccessful name written on paper, now a socio-economic grip witnessed by a community. The child's loss matters, yet the names of those actually harmed remain alongside it.

Raghav's Transparent Elephant and the Half-Sentence

At first, no elephant at all is visible within Raghav. Amid droplets of vanishing signals, a thin, transparent body gradually appears. The teeth of its crocodile are made of injunctions such as "Do not write; erase" and "Not relationships, but signals." The scene exposes not a deficiency inherent in modern communication, but the calculated use of a deceptive and incomplete language. The characters' dialogue makes the distinction between Meera's "privacy" and Saumya's "silence of the witness" particularly clear.

Lau's Metal Cage and Profit Without Place

Lau's elephant is enormous, yet it is confined within a metal cage. The sea and buildings of glass likewise assume the shape of an immense enclosure. The jaws of Lau's crocodile speak the language of capital without geographical attachment, for which a country, labour, and a river's history are merely risks. A desire to smell the earth begins to arise within him. This is not a completed moral transformation; it is a fearful curiosity, touched by the unfamiliar local landscape.

Broom's Hunger for Applause and the Appropriation of Interpretation

The elephant within Broom searches for applause at public meetings, while his crocodile becomes a hunger for glossy moral oratory. Language that makes pain into an example, the dead into theoretical cases, and the village into a research case-study is itself a crocodile here. The story discloses an uncomfortable likeness among the perspectives of critic, donor, and narrator: whoever turns another's testimony into an example rather than listening may seize control of its history. Criticism, too, must remain alert to this danger.

Satyavrat's Self-Examination: The Witness Is Not Neutral

Satyavrat initially stands as a spectator, but the stump discloses a conflict within him as well: the wish to listen for justice and the silence attached to his office. "Do not spare me either," he says. With this statement the witness and evaluator can no longer stand above criticism. The narrative refuses to make the viewpoint of institutional authority the only centre of judgment upon the characters; it makes the history of the observer visible as well. This is a powerful moment in the text's multiperspectival construction.

The Collective Response to the Recitation of Names

The final immense scene of elephant and crocodile ceases to concern one elephant or one crocodile alone. Parts of several inner elephants and crocodiles join together, and the children answer "Present" after each name. Through the refrain, the chapter's movement changes from a succession of spoken exchanges to the rhythm of a collective voice. Naming becomes an act of dramatic resistance, but its efficacy here is symbolic: no judicial verdict has been issued, nor has compensation been paid as a result of it.

The Ghost's Narrative Role: Moral Complexity

The old ghost teaches the children to recognise a captive being even within the person who has committed wrong. He distinguishes revenge from justice, while still insisting that a record of offences must be kept. His presence brings a tradition of folk narrative into modern conflicts involving digital technology and economic power. His statements risk turning into authoritative moral instruction; the children's challenging questions, however, prevent them from becoming a one-sided pronouncement.

Liberation Deferred: The Restraint of the Metaphor

At the end, the crocodile does not release its prey. Instead, the nature of its grip begins to become publicly visible. This is the chapter's decisive choice. If the elephant had been completely freed, the critique of an entire network of wrongdoing would have dissolved into a miraculous solution. The visibility of the grip becomes a precondition for organised social resistance. Despite the story's mythological expansion, this limited result restores a degree of realist ethical credibility to its conclusion.

From Game to School: A Structural Transformation

The public enactment of the inner elephant and crocodile teaches the children difficult questions; the following chapter turns this dramatic experience into rules for a school. This transition from a dream-world

experience to the formation of a social institution is an important movement in the novel's extended narrative. The unresolved question is how durably the communal experience of a magical night can be transformed into everyday labour and sustained education. The narrative leaves precisely this tension for the next chapter.

The Opening Folk Song and the Internal Displacement of the Next Title

Chapter 82 opens with the folk song "A School upon a Seat of Leaves," although its extended central narrative concerns the collective enactment of the elephant and crocodile within. The school is actually constructed in Chapter 83. The song might be read as a deliberately placed prelude; nevertheless, across Chapters 81–87, opening songs repeatedly correspond to the subjects of forthcoming chapters. Their placement therefore requires editorial examination. The present criticism does not silently treat the song as a direct scene from the chapter in which it appears.

Critical Section 184 | Original Chapter 83 — The Coconut-Leaf School

From a Mythic Night Vision to Construction at Dawn

"The game that descended into learning during the night"—this opening indication directly links the night of the inner elephant and crocodile with the morning of the school. The leap in narrative time is very small, but the kind of action has changed. In place of ghosts, transformations, and psychic battles come the clearing of sand, gathering of leaves, fetching of tiles, and construction of a pavilion. The long narrative's movement turns here from outward wonders to concrete descriptions of communal labour.

A School Without a Building: A New Definition of an Institution

Ananya calls it a school, but she does not seek government recognition or the furnishings of desks and benches. Its first lesson is listening to names before learning the alphabet. The conception locates the institution's legitimacy in shared rules rather than a certificate of authority. The making of a school is not simply an announcement: it acquires existence through a place marked out by people, open participation, and a recurring course of lessons. Before comparing it with contemporary debates about education, criticism must recognise the specificity of these events in the original narrative.

Four Corners: Names, Privacy, Labour, and Breath

Four corners are marked on the school's earthen plan—names, privacy, labour, and breath—with the stump at the centre. Through this arrangement the narrative gives a spatial design to its earlier conflicts across many subjects. Each corner preserves the memory of a previous narrative strand. The stump occupies the centre, but no monumental statue stands upon it. An empty bowl is set aside for new names. This vacant place preserves the ethical possibility of the future within the description.

The Ecological Meaning of Gathering Fallen Leaves

The children do not cut living coconut leaves; they collect those that have fallen of their own accord. Against the history of the severed Channa tree, this small choice matters. Reconstruction is not founded upon the further destruction of another green body. Earth, leaves, and stones have their own smells, rough textures, and finite lives. The novel registers environmental concern not only in declarations of regeneration but also in the measured act of choosing materials.

A New Plan on an Upturned Map: Reusing the Document

Ira draws the school's first plan on the reverse of a municipal map marked with lines for cutting. The upturned page of an older administrative drawing becomes the ground for a new communal inscription. Opposition to the archive is therefore not a matter of tearing up paper; it changes the right to use that paper. Even when the physical object remains the same, a change of writer and purpose can transform the relations of power it embodies.

Incomplete Inscription-Leaves and an Open Right to Authorship

The leaves bear indications such as "the bridge foundation," "the digital den," and "Meera's consent," rather than finished stories. Beneath each is a blank space reserved for a future listener or witness. This open procedure introduces the possibility of multiple authors in place of the narrator's complete control. A blank line is not an omission, but room for the next speaker. Nevertheless, whether writing actually continues in this way can be established only in the subsequent chapters.

Four Initial Rules: Body, Paper, and Silence

Devika proposes that grief should not be written down without permission; Meera insists that the body must not become a spectacle; Gop Kumar adds the need for a voice alongside the paper; and Satyavrat affirms the value of silence for listening. Each contribution springs from the character's previous experience. The rules are grounded in lived situations rather than claims to intellectual authority. This specificity saves the school from becoming a lifeless copy of a manifesto.

The Teacher's Objection and the Reversal of the Attendance Register

A teacher from the town laughs at the claim that writing four lines can establish a school. Ba distinguishes the examination-centred model of a building from the rules people live by. Importantly, the teacher is not humiliated and expelled from the narrative. He returns carrying his attendance register. Through this small act an opposing character becomes a participant in self-examination. The change of viewpoint results not from victory in a speech, but from reading a record anew.

Caste-Based Hesitation and the Shared Leaf

A child from a leatherworking family hesitates to pick up a leaf. A Brahmin child initially draws back, but then both take hold of the same leaf. Two hands resting on one shared object make a long social division visible in a momentary scene. The magical glimmer of a green line answers that contact within the story. Yet the text does not declare that the

caste system has ended because the children have held the same leaf. Their action begins the education still to come.

"Not Sprouted, but Assembled": Meera's Linguistic Correction

People say that, after the tree was cut down, the leaves "sprouted." Meera corrects them: "They did not sprout; they were assembled." This small revision of a verb expresses the chapter's narrative principle. In place of a miraculous, spontaneous rebirth, it keeps human work, time, and cooperation in view. Amid the novel's magical-realist atmosphere, this modest realist objection is exceptionally important. The proper relationship between nature and human labour is inscribed in a single verb.

The Sound of the Empty Bowl: An Alternative to the Bell

Ananya does not ring a metal school bell. Instead, she gently sounds an earthen bowl three times. The softness of the sound establishes a rhythm of education different from the thunder of ritual recitation or institutional discipline. The bowl also waits for names that are absent. One object performs two functions, expressing both a visible emptiness and an audible summons. Within the narrative, sound opens a time for listening rather than asserting ownership over memory.

The Fifth Rule: Let the Absent Be Called First

After the school opens, Ananya adds a fifth rule: whoever is absent must be called first. The dead, the missing, those excluded by caste, victims of digital fraud, and people concealed by shame are gathered into the expanding meaning of one term. "Absent" moves beyond an administrative list to signify an ethical incompleteness. The strength of this enlargement lies in its inclusiveness; its danger is that histories of distinct harms might be flattened into a single general category.

The Deferred Game of Humans and Ghosts and a Pause for Breath

At night, the possibility of playing kabaddi arises, but Ba tells the children to conserve their breath; the ghosts, too, do not play. The recurring rhythm of kabaddi is deliberately interrupted on this occasion. This non-event is important to the narrative's pace: rest follows labour, discipline follows celebration, and waiting for the next day follows the spectacle of metaphor. The novel thereby avoids exhausting itself in uninterrupted marvels.

The Half-Opened Suggestion of the Letter "U"

At night, the shadows of leaves and the severed stump form an unidentifiable shape upon the ground. To Satyavrat it resembles the letter

"उ" (u). The narrator does not identify the letter with certainty but leaves it as the character's supposition. Before the school's first lesson has happened, it appears as a script beginning to emerge. Body, object, and sound together produce a scene of the birth of a letter. Knowledge is made here, not imposed.

The Opening Song's Movement Ahead of the Narrative

Chapter 83 opens with the "Song of Presence," which relates more directly to the first lesson of Chapter 84 than to the construction of the school in the chapter's main story. The closing song, "The Seat of Leaves," corresponds to the present events. This double structure makes clear that opening and closing songs perform different functions. The repeated shift of opening songs towards the next subject warrants scrutiny, whether as deliberate foreshadowing or as a defect in editorial arrangement. Neither explanation should be asserted without examination.

Critical Section 185 | Original Chapter 84 — The First Lesson: Present

From the Word of Attendance to Social Existence

On the school's first morning, the word "present" itself performs the work of a bell. Before learning either the alphabet or arithmetic, the children practise standing alongside names. The novel transforms an ordinary school's daily administrative procedure into a dramatic ritual of social recognition. Through successive utterances of the same word, people who were recorded as absent find a place in public hearing. This does not immediately resolve their actual difficulties, but it changes the scene in which the narrative unfolds.

Sitamoni: A Life Concealed by a Household Form of Address

The first child gives her grandmother's real name, "Sitamoni." Within the household the woman had been called merely "that old woman." This slight difference in address exposes an entire social standing. An existence erased within the grammar of names, age, and kinship emerges again in the child's voice. The narrator does not recount a long biography; a single utterance and one line in the register leave room for the reader to gauge the extent of a lifetime's humiliation.

Bholaram: A Night-Time Name Enters the Day

Sonki gives the name of her maternal uncle, Bholaram. At home, the story of his disappearance into the river was told at night, while publicly the account circulated that he had gone away to earn a living. The entry "present from night into day" gives time a new social significance. Daylight here signifies not merely sunrise but the possibility of public speech. Inquiry into the actual circumstances of the death or disappearance at the river remains unfinished; reciting the name is no substitute for that inquiry.

Manglu Das: From the Caste Margin to the Centre of the Page

Some elderly people become uncomfortable when the name of Manglu Das, an ancestor from a leatherworking caste, is spoken. Devika writes his name in the middle of the register. This placement makes labour central to the page itself. The story translates an argument about "who comes first" into a question of where a name should be written. It presents resistance to caste humiliation not simply through elevated ideas but through the act of changing the layout of an actual record. The symbolic limit of this act remains evident: the social structure still exists.

An Unnamed Daughter and the Demands of Personal Safety

One child cannot speak the name of a sister who has been threatened. Rather than insist upon a public inscription, Meera proposes a descriptive formulation: "One daughter—present with dignity." The entry remembers the person without unnecessarily exposing her identity. At this point the plot complicates the earlier injunction to "speak every name." Collective courage in naming and an individual's right to refuse disclosure now inhabit the same register. This ethical tension is a formal achievement of the chapter.

The "M" on the Turned Stone: A Multiplicity of Possible Meanings

Ananya turns over an unmarked stone and discovers a half-written "म" (ma) beneath it. The children might connect it with Manglu, mother, or the dead. The narrative leaves several interpretations available for a single visible mark. Its mode of narration distinguishes sound, inference, and previously heard stories. The critic's task, however, is not to convert this educational scene into a test of reasoning in Navya-Nyaya. As a narrative event it is a dramatic exercise in the uncertainty of names and the patience required to listen.

Questions of Classical History: The Limits of Characters' Claims

Contested details of Gangesha's life return in a dialogue between the children's assembly and a pandit. Rather than answer several questions, Saumya proposes keeping the questions alive within the register. Critically, the scene is best read as an expression of historical consciousness inside the novel and a challenge to inherited dominance. To present assertions made by characters about named historical scholars as established facts outside the fictional text would be an unwarranted leap beyond the literary evidence.

Phulkumari's Amulet: The Letters Perish, the Voice Survives

An elderly woman shows an old amulet holding her mother's name. The paper inside has decayed, and she fears that opening it will destroy it. Saumya does not force it open. The woman herself speaks her mother's name: "Phulkumari." The loss of the written object and the survival of a voice carried by oral inheritance lend the scene its fragility. The amulet's thread loosening of its own accord is a magical response. Its importance lies in the resonance of a private name, not in scientific verification of a record.

The Pandit's Objection and the Sequence of Public Replies

A traditional pandit declares the school's lesson contrary to scripture. Ananya and Ira ask what ethical authority a system retains if it consumes people's names. In this exchange, the argument moves from individual conduct to communal legitimacy. Yet the pandit's brief opposition falls silent rather quickly, which is also a limitation of the narrative technique: the opposing side in a complex structural conflict appears relatively easy to defeat. The difference between the argument's force and the scene's dramatic brevity must be preserved in criticism.

The Ritual Rhythm of the Collective "Present"

During the evening recitation of names, a collective response follows each one. The repetitions lengthen the reader's sense of time even though relatively little external action occurs. Through this recurrence, attendance becomes an enduring ritual of memory. The sequence of names holds open the possibility of adding other lives each day. The narrator makes this rhythm into a seemingly spontaneous collective music. Still, an assumption that everyone feels equal enthusiasm could reduce the place allotted to social disagreement.

A New Covenant Between Memory and Privacy

"Memory cannot be made by cutting away privacy," Meera declares in a crucial reply. Earlier, the stones of names had chiefly opposed forgetting; now the right to inscribe them carries conditions. Some names will be written in full, others partially, while some will be withheld until families grant permission. This modest formal arrangement amounts to a concrete development in the narrative's ethics. Amid many images of social powerlessness, the author establishes a clear boundary around personal dignity.

A Magical Event Without Spectacle

Phulkumari's amulet opening, the spontaneous rustle of leaves, and the trembling of a green point upon the stump are all extraordinary occurrences. Yet the children neither proclaim a miracle nor turn them into a media spectacle. Such restraint in magical realism operates almost as a governing rule: the vision should enlarge listening, not create a new display of exploitation. By placing limits upon its own wonders, the narrative shows a capacity for self-criticism.

From Day to Night: The Narrative Necessity of the Women's Assembly

Amid the names spoken during the day, the women realise that certain experiences can be voiced only within the protection of a gathering at night. Meera leaves a blank page and indicates that the next lesson will be organised by the women. The ending succeeds as a declaration of incompleteness: any claim to universal presence remains inadequate without conditions protecting women's private experiences. The next chapter thus arises from a specific narrative necessity.

The Opening Song's Inclination Towards the Women's Circle

Chapter 84, titled "The First Lesson: Present," opens with the song "The Women's Bright Watch," whose principal subject is the night assembly in Chapter 85. The concluding collective song of presence, by contrast, belongs to the lesson of the current chapter. The opening and closing songs therefore point towards different narrative times. This recurring shift in subject matter supplies concrete textual grounds for examining the editing of songs across the work. It must neither automatically be called an error nor treated, without evidence, as deliberate foreshadowing.

Critical Section 186 | Original Chapter 85 — The Women's Night Assembly

From the Daytime Lesson to an Autonomous Space at Night

The women's assembly is not merely an extension of the school's daytime lessons: the time of meeting, the participants, and the authority to record testimony are all constituted anew. As soon as the men's debate subsides, the women gather of their own accord around the stump. There is neither a formal invitation nor a chairperson's platform. In this informal founding, the power to make events happen lies with the women who assemble. Night is not simply darkness; it is the time in which a partly protected, confidential space can be created amid danger.

The Sensuous Composition of Bodily Smell, Dew, and Silence

The description of night brings together fine drops of dew, frogs calling, splashing water, and damp clothes. Instead of announcing "women's suffering" in the abstract, the novel constructs an atmosphere around the women's embodied circumstances. They do not come to perform upon a platform: they arrive bearing shirts, bundles, staffs, lamps, and water. Even before anyone speaks, these objects reveal the unequal burdens borne by particular lives.

Meera's First Words: Protection, Not the Appropriation of Authority

Meera does not simply "open" the meeting; she first establishes rules for its protection. Whoever tells a story will retain ownership of that story; nothing may be written down or exhibited without permission; silence, too, counts as presence. Thus a character who has become a leader does not seize other women's lives in the name of the assembly. The centre of narrative authority shifts away from the social audience towards the consent of the person recounting her experience. This measure of responsibility applies equally to the practice of writing the story.

Ujjwal's Mother's Shirt: The Object Speaks First

Ujjwal's mother places her son's old shirt near the stump. Through the traces of salt, the remembrance of sweat, and the fact that it has not been washed, the narrator gives grief a material substance. The mother's testimony connects the violence of digital fraud with familial silence and the victim's shame. Her capacity to say, "I, too, could not listen to his fear," does not glorify self-accusation; it constitutes a complicated form of self-address within mourning.

Devika's Testimony: The Meaning of Shame Imposed on the Victim

Alongside the financial fraud itself, Devika exposes the social manoeuvre by which victims are declared foolish or disreputable. A discussion of digital crime centred on money becomes a problem of whether women and young people have the right to speak. Inside the assembly, this secondary injury is named collectively for the first time. Within a single narrative movement, the author links the fraudster's invisible network with the visible shame produced in the victim's home. The direction of accusation thereby turns away from the victim and towards the perpetrator and the surrounding social climate of silence.

From "Munna's Wife" to Phulkumari: Ownership of One's Name

The widow of a bridge worker had earlier been entered in the register under the relational designation "Munna's wife." At the night assembly she declares, "My name is Phulkumari." This self-identification does more than correct a name: it inserts a woman's distinct journey into the history of labour. Alongside the account of the worker submerged near a bridge pier, the image of feet carrying food and the labour marked upon cracked heels prepares the ground for the following chapter.

Saumya's Closed Notebook: The Self-Restraint of Writing

Saumya keeps her notebook closed at first. Later she writes only the heading "Evidence of the Body," leaving the page beneath it blank. This imposes the limit of informed consent upon any presumed entitlement of the writer or researcher. Hearing a story of trauma does not automatically confer the right to make a text of it. The critical work itself is consequently called into question: to what extent does a critic's retelling preserve the dignity of the people represented? The original event heightens the significance of such restraint.

Ira's Diasporic Perspective and Women's History

Ira questions her former way of understanding women's lives in Mithila through pictures, folk songs, and textile art viewed abroad. The village woman becomes, for her, not a colourful representative figure but a living person capable of reasoning and argument. Ira's speech introduces the question of suppressed women's memories associated with Gangesha's life. The criticism must read the historical allegation in this scene as part of a character's debate over memory, not certify it as historical fact on the authority of evidence external to the source.

Caste, Love, and Surveillance of the Body

An elderly woman from Sarayu's lineage connects the caste system's insistence on caste purity with control over love, marriage, and women's

bodies. The social limits of the narrative broaden from the family to the larger discipline imposed by caste. The night assembly gives this severe relationship a voice grounded in direct experience. Yet the injuries suffered by different families are compressed here into brief statements. A reader must recognise that one declaration neither proves all the different causes of violence nor brings them to an end.

The Red Thread: A Changing Meaning of Bondage

Meera gives each woman a red thread, but the threads are not tied to the stump as public offerings. Each speaker keeps hers upon her own wrist. The object is made a private sign of possession and remembrance. Its recurrence links it to several earlier rules of protection, yet the requirement that a woman retain it herself limits a collective symbol through personal rights. This subtle turn in the metaphor prevents a patriarchal community from appropriating what belongs to the individual.

"Confidentially Present": The Right Not to Speak a Name

A young woman asks that the name of the person she loves should not be made public. The register records her as "Confidentially present." This brief phrase is a necessary amendment to the rule of "present" established on the first day. If an account of collective memory requires everyone to disclose their identity, the safety of people exposed to violence will be compromised. The scene imagines a complex narrative practice capable of protecting confidentiality while seeking communal truth—a more mature construction than sentimental discussion of remembrance alone.

The Circle of Women Ghosts and an Acknowledged Place

At the end of the night, the shadows of women ghosts appear by the water's edge. They do not play; they seem instead to measure the circumference of the gathering. The formerly male-dominated symbol of ghostly kabaddi is interrogated anew through women's difficulty in finding a place of their own. The magical scene makes a history of women's experiences visible. The shadows remain without definite identities, itself a sign of how difficult it is to recover forgotten names. Yet the attraction of mystery does not obscure the actual words spoken by the women.

Five Points of Agreement: Rules, Proposals, and Results

Before dawn the assembly settles five matters: permission to tell or record testimony; the question of caste violence; redirecting the shame attached to fraud; recording the names of women at home alongside those of labourers; and the dignity of privacy. There is no formal ballot or government order. The statement that these matters were "settled"

describes a form of collective agreement distinct from institutional procedure. The criticism makes no claim that legislation has thereby been enacted. What emerges is a shared framework for future conduct, to be tested in the next chapter's archive of footprints.

From a Cracked Heel Towards the Story of the Bridge

At dawn Phulkumari shows her heel and says, "Tomorrow, let us read the feet." This bodily indication generates the subject of the next chapter. In the story's ordinary sequence of events, the bridge has been the site of an earlier accident; after the women's assembly it is to become a wider archive of relations of labour. The fact that a new scene begins after the women have spoken is important: the story of the male labourers can no longer be enclosed within men's names alone.

The Opening Labour Song's Anticipation

Chapter 85 opens with the song "A Path Made from the Dust of Feet," whose lines centre upon workers' footprints and the paths of labour. The main chapter, however, concerns the confidential speech of the women's assembly, while the principal scene involving footprints occurs in Chapter 86. The closing song, "The Women's Night," corresponds clearly to the present narrative episode. The documentary indication becomes stronger here that the opening song's correspondence with the succeeding chapter may be more than coincidence, raising again the question of whether the songs have been systematically displaced by one chapter.

Critical Section 187 | Original Chapter 86 — The Workers' Feet

A Change of Scene from the Stump to the Unfinished Bridge

At the close of the women's night assembly, the question of cracked heels has arisen. The next morning the children take earthen bowls, soot, a register, and blank leaves towards the bridge. For the first time in an extended sequence, the narrative's centre moves from the school's protected enclosure to the site of the accident. This change of place expands the utterance "present" to include the marks left by physical lives. The bridge's half-built structure is neither a lifeless monument nor a mere symbol of development, but the arrested remainder of earlier labour.

Two Views of the Bridge: Distant Splendour and Near-at-Hand Exhaustion

Seen from a distance, the bridge is recognisable through iron, official paint, cement, and the glitter of an inauguration ribbon. Close up, sinking earth around the piers and invisible exhaustion come into view. This alteration of distance is a camera-like movement of the narrator's observational position. The reader is compelled to see one face of the structure in the official signs of inauguration and the other in the earth of the dead workers. The measurement of physical distance becomes a measure of moral experience.

Munna's Uncle's Footprint: The Extraordinary Ordinary

Munna Paswan's uncle stands barefoot beside a pier and speaks of his brother's sweat. He places his cracked sole in an earthen bowl and its impression is taken on a leaf. Here it is not a ghost but the rough contact of a living body that occupies the narrative's centre. A consensually given footprint, rather than a photograph or an official biometric trace, offers another means of inscribing memory. The narrator gives this act sensory depth through the coolness of the impression and the sharp sound accompanying it.

Women's Unpaid Paths Beside Men's Wage Labour

At first the women ask why their own footprints should be required, since they had not performed paid work directly on the bridge. Devika's question—"Are the feet that carry food not engaged in labour?"—widens the definition of a workplace. The scene connects domestic food preparation, transport, waiting, and unpaid care to the economy of the bridge's piers. The voices heard at the women's assembly on the previous night now become part of the bridge's material record.

The Transformation of Aruni's Engineering Perspective

Aruni measures plans, loads, depths, and proportions of building materials, but today speaks of the fatigue of feet. The narrative's strength lies not in rejecting engineering knowledge but in identifying its limits. Technical safety and respect for workers are two distinct and necessary levels of responsibility. "A bridge that does not preserve the names of its workers is an unfinished bridge": this declaration establishes a metaphorical connection between actual incompleteness in construction and incompleteness in social memory.

The Differing Sizes of Impressions: A Visual Register of Many Bodies

Footprints of the old and young, women and men, large and small, grey and dark, emerge upon the leaves. Instead of the uniform statistical category "workforce," sensory distinctions are brought before the reader. Alongside names, the reader encounters the shapes of lives that walked and leapt upon the earth. Each different body is accorded equal dignity in this visual register, but equality does not mean that everyone has had the same experience. Every impression holds the possibility of a different story.

The Memorial Plaque Proposal and Ownership of the Object

Chandrapal's people arrive carrying a prepared plaque for the "Martyr Workers' Memorial Wall." Its dimensions, lettering, and location have already been determined. The children insist that the names will be inscribed, but that they must first read the feet. This confrontation reveals a difference in power between printing names and hearing their social meanings. The power to erect the board generally lies with the contractor's group; the affected families wish to retain the authority to say what the names mean.

The Sentence of Consent: Whose Image Is a Footprint?

Meera makes clear that images of footprints, narratives, or tears are not to be used for publicity without the families' consent. A statement of permission is added to the back of every leaf. Here the earlier rules of the women's assembly are applied to the material archive of labour. The children are learning not merely sympathy but a procedure governing rights of use. From the standpoint of narrative method, an ethical idea becomes a particular sequence of actions: ask, take the impression, write, and safeguard.

"Not Data, but Trust": Redrawing the Archive's Boundaries

Looking at the footprints, Gop Kumar says, "Not data, but trust." The remark does not declare data or measurement wholly useless. It is situated against the background of earlier theft, photographs taken without

consent, and control exercised through contracts. Trust here is not simply a personal virtue; it is a relationship constituted by consent, purpose, and the responsibility of whoever keeps the records. The brief remark acquires its force from its resonance throughout the larger digital narrative cycle.

Kabaddi's New Boundary: Feet Versus Paper

Ananya draws a line in the earth, placing feet on one side and paper on the other. The children play a game in which they carry paper plaques and circle within the ring of footprints. The earlier kabaddi of ghosts is transformed into a dramatic rehearsal of a people's archive. Holding one's breath, crossing the boundary, and returning now momentarily demonstrate the priority of labour over documentation. The game is not a new law, but it becomes a bodily language of the sense of justice.

Satyavrat's Footprint Refused

Satyavrat Mehta removes his shoes and sets his feet upon the earth, but Ananya refuses to take his impression. "Your silence has already been written down," she tells him. The reply distinguishes the place of a witness from that of a worker. Sympathy alone cannot entitle an official to occupy the experience of the injured. The scene is powerful precisely because it does not exempt even a character sympathetic to justice from the boundaries set by the community. The old power's gesture of humility cannot purchase a new central position.

The Distant Sound of Sandals: The Return of Absent Bodies

At night, the sound of sandals walking seems to come from the direction of the bridge, though nobody is there. The sentence begins with "perhaps the wind" and leaves open the ghostliness of memory. Rather than supplying proof of ghosts, the scene makes an audible remainder of the names erased from the history of labour. Placed together, name-stones and footprint-leaves turn documentation from a static list of persons into a collection of traces of lives once in motion. The novel's aural magical realism is present here in a restrained form.

The Difference Between an Archive of Feet and Social Compensation

The new section of the register is called the "Archive of Feet," and the families answer "present." Yet unpaid wages, the safety of the piers, an inquiry into the accident, and the determination of responsibility remain unresolved. The language appropriate to memory may provide a foundation for judicial and economic remedies; it cannot substitute for them. A realist reading of this chapter requires that distinction, so that an emotionally affecting collection of impressions is not mistaken for complete justice for workers.

The Final Turn Towards a Fast from Screens

As the group returns from the unfinished bridge, Ananya announces that screens will be kept off the following day. Having read the feet, it becomes necessary to open eyes and ears. This transition draws a line from the archive of bodies towards the education of perception. Chapter 86 opens with "The Screen's Rest, the Eyes' Festival," a song that more clearly anticipates the events of Chapter 87. Its concluding song, "The Dust of Workers' Feet," accords with the chapter itself. The forward placement of the opening song again calls for examination.

Critical Section 188 | Original Chapter 87 — The Fast from Screens

A Voluntary Declaration and Disagreement in the Village

The children's proposal for a fast from screens immediately divides the village into two camps. Questions arise about contact for medical treatment, messages from sons living in the city, and the shopkeeper's transactions. The narrator does not ignore these uses. The children keep routes open for emergencies and make the fast voluntary. Without those conditions the story would become an anti-technological command; listening to practical objections lends credibility to the fast as a narrative event.

The Earthen "Screen-Pot": A Temporary Rearrangement of Devices

An earthen pot is placed near the stump, and mobile phones or tablets are deposited in cloth bags. The material arrangements of the fast are ordinary: no device is destroyed, nor is anything seized under compulsion. What generates power here is not a newly asserted right over other people but an interval during which the use of devices is suspended. A day's pause creates a different expanse for sensory experience. The story does not announce a future without technology; it renegotiates the relationship with it.

Devika's Mobile Phone and a Pause in Personal Mourning

Devika trembles as she puts down her phone, because it still holds the shadow of Ujjwal's last message. The screen is not merely a vehicle of addiction or spectacle; it is also a repository of private grief. To undertake the fast is not to dishonour this memory, but to decide that for one day it will not become a cage. Within the same device are threads of comfort, fear, and crime. This complexity prevents technology from being assigned a single, unqualified moral character.

The Different Pauses of Meera, Saumya, and Satyavrat

Meera remembers the injury to her dignity caused by digital scrutiny. Saumya decides to hear news from people's mouths rather than through the news screen. Satyavrat admits his old habit of leaving meetings midway whenever his phone rings. All three participate in the same fast, but their experiences are different. The narration's multiple focal positions do not market one public measure as producing identical results. Each character is given a distinct reason connected with events previously witnessed.

Ba's Spectacles: An Unequal Object in the Fast

Ba has no mobile phone. She places her spectacles beside the pot and says that today she will listen. The gesture does not put spectacles in the same technological category as phones, but symbolically extends the commitment to listening. Criticism cannot describe spectacles and mobile phones as devices bearing equivalent risks. Even while acknowledging their difference, the scene makes the changing priority of the senses memorable. Through the conjunction of objects, the narrative establishes a relationship among ways of perceiving.

From Notification Bells to the Sounds of Hearth and Well

When the tinkling of mobile notifications ceases, the cock's call, the clatter of a ladle, the creak of the well-rope, and children's laughter come forward. The story's soundscape changes through a different selection of what is heard. These sounds existed earlier too, but the characters did not give them their attention. This is not a return to an imagined "pure village"; it is a redistribution of time available to the senses. Through a collective act, the novel recomposes the reader's experience of hearing.

"Reading by Mouth": From Digital Lists to People's Narratives

On this day the usual roll call of names is replaced by "reading by mouth." Families speak in their own voices of the bridge, the flood, medicine, digital anxiety, and old experiences of deception. The sources of narration become multiple speakers: rather than one omniscient report, short oral scenes are joined together. Isolation in the village emerges as an opportunity exploited by digital fraud. By changing the medium of narration, the story changes how a problem is seen. Beyond switching off devices, listening to other human beings becomes the new medium.

The Handwritten Ledger and the Social Face of Debt

The shopkeeper writes transactions by hand, and alongside debtors' names remembers rice supplied to a widow, partial repayments, and older relationships. Numbers had previously appeared upon a screen; when the paper ledger is opened, their social stories become present. This contrast does not assert that paper is inherently morally superior. Rather, it provides an opportunity to reconnect figures with their contexts. The earlier novel has also shown deception carried out on paper, so it would be wrong to conclude here that "paper always tells the truth."

A New Kabaddi: One Name and a Story Completed Together

The children cross a line while calling out a name; if one player cannot finish the story, another continues it. Rules of victory and defeat are transformed into a cooperative education in memory. Here the word

"present" signals agreement among the people rather than applause. The old rhythm of the ghosts' kabaddi becomes embodied in the games of living children. Memory does not depend upon a single person's breath: a narrative possibility emerges in which it survives through a collective sequence.

Women's Right to Look: Switching Off a Device Is Not Enough

Meera and the other women make clear that switching off a mobile phone is not enough. Seeing another person's pain, love, tears, or body does not confer ownership of it. Through this assertion, the ethical centre of the fast shifts from the absence of screens to responsibility in looking. The central idea is connected with the novel's wider narrative of privacy: even without a mobile phone, a gaze within the village may become exploitative. Technology is not the sole cause of wrongdoing.

Falling Clicks: A Distant View of the Antagonist

As the village's activity on the app declines, Chandrapal becomes anxious. The flow of clicks and donations slows. At this point the narrator abruptly cuts to the circuits of economic control in the distant city. This scene shows that a local pause can register as a measurable change in digital revenue. Yet one day's decline in clicks does not mean the network has been destroyed. The earlier narrative thread of Raghav's obstructed messages suggests that the struggle over control remains unresolved.

The Outsider Researcher's Label of "Detox"

Broom's researchers want to classify the experience as a "digital detox," but the villagers' actions concern the names of the dead, privacy, workers' bodies, and fear of fraud. A familiar term from the language of health cannot encompass this entire history. The confrontation between scholarly classification and the contexts of lived experience makes demands upon criticism itself within the story: a concept can be useful, but cutting facts down to fit inside it would amount to a violent rewriting.

Rules for Returning Mobile Phones and an Unfinished Revolution

In the evening the bags are opened and the devices returned, accompanied by rules: keeping them switched off during the nightly roll call, seeking permission before photographing someone's tears, and reading fraudulent messages collectively. The narrative describes communal restraint in the use of technology rather than its destruction. The fast has been a single organised event; how far daily practice will change remains a question for the future. This unresolved temporal structure reduces the risk that the story will become a cheap sermon against technology.

A Green Point in the Sky and Preparations for Ira's Letter

In the open sky after the pause from screens, a tiny green point becomes visible. Some call it a star, others an aircraft, and still others an illusion. Multiple interpretations remain possible. Ira decides to write to children of the diaspora, returning the experience to a written medium. The irony is effective: the outcome of the fast is the wish to connect with distant people through a letter, not a wholesale rejection of communication. The first action of the following chapter grows from this decision.

The Place of the Opening Letter-Song and the Overall Conclusion

Chapter 87 opens with the song "The Dawn of Home in a Letter from Abroad," although its main narrative concerns the fast from screens. The song is more directly aligned with Chapter 88, "Ira's Letter to Children Abroad," while the closing song, "The Fast from Screens," encapsulates the present chapter. The meaning of this recurring arrangement of two songs can be established only by examining the sequence of opening songs across the complete work. At this point the criticism records the discrepancy and leaves the uncertainty open.

Critical Section 189 | Original Chapter 88 — Ira's Letter to Children Abroad

The Rebirth of the Letter after the Fast from Screens

Communication resumes in Chapter 88 after the one-day abstention from screens in Chapter 87. Ira writes to children living in distant countries; the scene does not present the total abandonment of technology as a solution. Instead, the narrative confronts the ethical use of its instruments. The very same screen may facilitate fraud or restore the names and relationships of a family living far away. The transition between chapters is therefore from prohibition to responsible use. The fast assumes a concrete consequence in a character's life through the act of writing a letter.

The Stump, the Stone, and the Leaf as a Writing Desk

Seated on the veranda of the Coconut-Leaf School, Ira looks at the felled stump of the Channa tree and the stones bearing names. The first sentence of her letter seems to be written in the veins of a leaf; the material surface of writing and historical memory converge. The reader sees not only what the letter says but also the circumstances that make it possible. The contact of pen and leaf, the incomplete utterance on a stone, and a green spot lend sensuous credibility to the narration. Against geographical distance, these local objects serve as bridges of language.

"Not a Holiday Picture": A Challenge to the Diasporic Gaze

In Ira's address, the village is not a tourist picture but a responsibility. Beyond the alluring signs of home-cooked rice, ponds, fish, and folk songs, she adds the stories of workers buried in the bridge, digital fraud, women's privacy, and delayed justice. This account interrogates a facile nostalgia for the ancestral home. By bringing present injustice into the centre of recollection, the narrator makes it impossible to select only decorative images of the past. The reader must hold the beauty of the village and its obligations within the same field of vision.

Errors of Pronunciation and the Possibility of Relationship

Ananya asks whether children born abroad will be able to write their ancestors' names. Ira accepts the right to make an effort rather than demanding complete linguistic competence. This brief exchange turns the intergenerational rupture of language under displacement into a narrative conflict. Mispronouncing a name is not equivalent to a crime, but refusing to learn its correct form can render the distance from memory permanent. The letter offers the possibility of an inheritance acquired through

learning: one is not automatically the owner of a lineage but may become a new student of its relationships.

Rules Within the Letter: Instruction and Narrative

Ira asks visiting children to listen to a person's name before taking a photograph, to observe silence before beginning research, and to pay attention before making a donation. At this point the narration becomes overtly instructive. Yet the rules have not appeared in a vacuum: previous chapters have shown the commercial exploitation of memory, fabricated tributes, and images displayed without consent. The language of counsel thus derives its significance from remembered events. The essential test is whether the characters subsequently observe these rules. The writing of the letter is not, by itself, conclusive evidence of change.

The Interval before a Reply and the Pace of Epistolary Narrative

The first response arrives two days after the letter is sent. The story does not fill this interval with extensive description; the pause between writing and reply conveys the actual distance separating the correspondents. Brief answers from Neel in Toronto, a girl in Melbourne, and the child of a labourer in Dubai enter the narrative in succession. Each takes up a different element of the original letter: the pronunciation of names, the village's difficult truths, and unnamed labour in the construction of buildings. Through this sequence, monologue becomes polyphony, and the right to respond passes from the writer to children who resemble the letter's readers.

Neelkanth, Melbourne, and Dubai: A Triangle of Places

The Toronto boy was called "Neelkanth" by his grandmother; the Melbourne girl wants to learn despite being told that the language is "troublesome"; and the Dubai child asks about the unacknowledged labour of his father, who constructs buildings. These episodes are not travel writing. They are miniature narratives showing how memory carried across the sea is translated into distinct social circumstances. The question from Dubai gives a new global setting to the workers' feet in Chapter 86. The children answering Ira do not become fixed replicas of the ancestral village: their own experiences change the meaning of that village.

"Present from Afar": A New Category of Absence

The village children make a special stone for the distant replies, inscribed "Present from afar." The earlier rite of reading names now crosses geographical boundaries. Social presence becomes possible without physical attendance, but it is not reduced to a digital click. The willingness to learn, the accurate pronunciation of a name, and the discipline of listening to

testimony constitute the basis of this presence. The memorial stone is a material symbol, not a certificate of legal citizenship. Maintaining that distinction is essential to a responsible critical reading.

The Desire for Institutional Capture and Ownership of the Letter

Batuknath's network of trusts sees the replies of diasporic children as opportunities for donations, events, and public platforms. Broom's research group attempts to call the exchange a "diasporic-memory network." Ira makes clear that an address to children is not raw material for a fund or a cultural spectacle. The central struggle is whether dialogue can remain autonomous or become institutional property. The dignity of an exchange of letters depends less upon its technical medium than upon the limits set on control over it. Unauthorised reproduction can itself become another form of appropriation.

Dreams and the Limited Magic of the Digital Glow

Children abroad dream of warm earth beneath snow, Maithili letters in the waves of the sea, and a labourer's footprints in the desert. These images figuratively extend the effect of the letter. The narrator does not establish that every dream results from objectively supernatural communication. The momentary sign "present" appearing on a phone creates a literary correspondence; the point of the fantasy is that questions about the village have awakened in distant minds. To impose one definitive interpretation on these dreams would diminish their productive ambiguity.

From the End of the Letter to the Public Hearing

The responses from abroad open another page of questions in the village children's register, and eventually a date is fixed for Satyavrat's public hearing. In the arrangement of events, the letter is not an external appendix but a means of extending collective deliberation. A response such as "We are present, but we still have much to learn" marks not a declaration of heroism but the beginning of modest participation. The chapter ends by anticipating how these distant voices will be recorded at the forthcoming hearing. The letter is not made the final verdict; it becomes an invitation to the next public act of narration.

The Displaced Subject of the Anticipatory Folk Song

The chapter opens with a folk song titled "A Gathering for Unheard Voices," whose principal images are a circular hearing and the lowering of the platform. The chapter's central action, however, is the writing of letters to children abroad. The next chapter, 89, deals directly with the public hearing. A pattern in which a folk song sings the subject of the following chapter in advance is again apparent. This may be deliberate

foreshadowing, or the song may have shifted position during editing. Both possibilities should remain open to the reader: similarity between titles alone cannot settle the question.

Critical Section 190 | Original Chapter 89 — Satyavrat's Public Hearing

Reversing the Arrangement of the Official Platform

The novel evokes the familiar scene of a government public hearing: a raised platform, a microphone, officials, police, and testimony hurriedly restricted to two minutes. It then places the participants in a circle on the ground beside the stump of the Channa tree. The difference is not merely a matter of stage design. The time accorded to speakers, the bodily posture of listeners, and ownership of the record are all transformed. Satyavrat withdraws his claim to preside, while the children acquire the right to write. Spatial elevation, made an image of legal and administrative dominance, is overturned by the narrator.

The Register, the Dried Leaf, and the Empty Bowl

Three objects stand at the centre of the circle: an old register, a leaf from the Channa tree, and an empty earthen bowl. The first signifies recorded names, the second ecological memory, and the third testimony that has not yet found speech. The emptiness of the bowl matters because room is reserved for untold stories from the very beginning of the meeting. This grouping of objects is more than emotional decoration; it begins to stand in for formal rules governing the platform. Criticism must nevertheless preserve the distinction between a written page and actual legal proceedings.

Choosing the First Witness: A Woman of the Leatherworking Community

The hearing opens not with Ira's letter or a distant political pronouncement but with the question of an elderly woman from the leatherworking community. She raises the social prohibition that kept her daughter from studying the scriptures. This initial voice brings the unequal positions of labour, gender, and caste to the centre of the story. The narrative connects a reference to Gangesha with this character's remembered account; the critic need not pronounce upon the historical authenticity of that life here. What matters formally is that a neglected character controls the full duration of her own question.

The Moment When the Pen Is Stopped

Satyavrat begins writing as soon as he hears the first witness, but Ananya stops his hand so that the question can be completed. This small intervention reorganises the order of listening, recording, and interpretation. The official's habitual first response is to put testimony into

words immediately; the child first protects the speaker's time. The scene moves beyond the question of "who will write" to ask "when will writing begin?" Its temporal force lies in this interruption: the interval before inscription becomes part of the witness's uninterrupted right to speak.

A Child Born Abroad: A Second Layer of Testimony

The question raised in Ira's letter returns to the hearing. Tension emerges between the pronunciation of a grandmother's name by a child born abroad and the standardised spelling used at school. Gop Kumar proposes a category such as "diasporic memory," but Ba insists that the grandmother's name be written first. The exchange seeks a place for personal address within the archive, apart from caste or administrative classification. The letter in Chapter 88 is no longer merely material to be remembered; it has acquired a claim to be heard in public.

The "Temporary Worker" and a Permanent Water Burial

A young man from a bridge worker's family says that his father was a temporary worker on paper but became permanent in the water. The contractual transience of labour and the irreversibility of death meet in opposing directions within this sentence. Bitterly ironic language renders a cruel historical loss memorable. The author does not show the final determination of compensation or the bridge disaster here. The force of the family's declaration is the central narrative event. Its arrival upon the public platform marks an achievement of the plot, not the completion of judicial redress.

A New Meaning for the Postponement of Judgment

Satyavrat says that he will deliver no decision that day; the testimony will be allowed to retain its own form. In an ordinary administrative narrative, this delay might amount to inaction, but here it answers an earlier practice of coercion by giving people time to speak. A critical question nevertheless remains: endless listening must not become an excuse for withholding concrete rights from those who have suffered. The novel has reached only the first stage of this test. Satyavrat's altered role indicates an ethical direction for future action; it cannot substitute for that action.

Raghav's Old Message: The Verbal Entry of an Absent Character

Gop Kumar brings a copy of an old message from Raghav, setting out a sequence from emotion to content, from content to funds, and from funds to control. Raghav is not present at the gathering, but his previously written language enters the discussion. This is the technique of bringing an absent antagonist into the scene through documentary quotation. The narrator does not conjure a miraculous appearance; old writing acquires a

new significance when read aloud by another character. A scheme for controlling social memory is rendered legible through a compact chain of terms.

Kabaddi as a Moving Form of Oral Testimony

During the hearing, children draw the lines for a game of kabaddi. Rather than stop the game as a disturbance to the assembly, Ba turns it into an act of reading names. Each time a stone bearing a name is touched, a family answers "Present." The double rhythm of the stationary circle and the moving game changes the pace of the story. The hearing no longer consists solely of spoken statements: through breath, boundaries, feet, and response, it becomes a bodily ritual. Yet the symbolic force of play does not by itself establish the sufficiency of legal evidence or the delivery of actual relief.

The Weight of Silence and the Lifting of the Bowl

At day's end, the empty bowl seems difficult to lift under the weight of testimony left unspoken. The elderly leatherworking woman calls for caste, shame, fear, and rank to be set aside; when Ananya touches it, the bowl rises. The magical scene gives narrative weight to what could not be said. The decisive movement of focal attention is from an adult's experience to the child's action. The breach of physical law should not be made into a theory of reality; it is more appropriately read as an artistic expression of the right to possess one's memories.

The Birth of Rules: From Hearing to Writing

After the hearing, the children write that "rules are needed to guard names." The first rule prohibits erasure of names; later rules address silence, bodily integrity, privacy, screens, caste, and the transformation of pain into spectacle. Here the narrator moves from an event of listening towards institutional expression. These rules are not a sacred text already imposed from above but a document emerging in response to several incomplete testimonies. The ending becomes a necessary prelude to the next chapter, "The Constitution of Names," granting continuity to the public scene through writing.

The Folk Song's Subject and the Coming Constitution

Chapter 89 opens with "The People's Law of the Leaf," a song that imagines a constitution written upon dry leaves and rules drawn from nature. Its principal action, however, is the day of public hearing; the law upon leaves is elaborated in Chapter 90. The song seems to run ahead as a synopsis of the coming narrative. Such anticipation can be a literary function of songs in a long novel, but its recurrence also raises the question

of editorial displacement. This reading therefore keeps the principal event, the song, and the next chapter distinct as separate levels of textual evidence.

Critical Section 191 | Original Chapter 90 — The Constitution of Names

The Day after the Public Hearing: An Institutional Turn in the Narrative

After the hearing, the teacher places dried leaves in the schoolroom and announces that today they will "write, not read." At this opening, the classroom turns away from the old hierarchy of instruction towards the collective making of rules. The children laugh because of their earlier experiences of orders issued by administrators, courts, and schools. The teacher explains that rules will arise not from above but from the names protected beside the stump. The school becomes a new narrative stage upon which children are not merely listeners but creative founders of an institution.

"Look First at the Wrong": An Alternative Voice for a Preamble

Ba declares that a society recording only its own glories composes a genealogy, not a constitution. The founding of communal rules therefore begins with self-criticism rather than self-congratulation. The story refuses to depict the remembered village simply as an ideal. The wounds of labour, privacy, caste, and fraud remain enduring materials of its history. The didactic quality is clear, yet it is grounded in scenes of injury already witnessed by readers in preceding chapters. Without those experiences, the word "constitution" might have remained an empty slogan.

The Sequential Construction of Fourteen Rules

The original chapter gathers fourteen rules in order. They begin with names, privacy, the body, and the contracting-out of memory; pass through caste oppression, the limits of documents, the subordination of technology, and kabaddi; and extend at the end to priority for the unnamed, the accounting of silence, water, responsibilities towards the diaspora, forgiveness, and guardianship across generations. Reading this list as nothing but a manifesto would overlook its narrative function. Each rule bears a condensed remembrance of preceding events in the novel, making the list a kind of index internal to the story itself.

The Many Sites of a Name and the Multimedial Archive

Devika's first rule calls for names to be preserved not only in large letters on monuments but also in domestic forms of address, wage books, court records, hospitals, schools, and stones along the water's edge. This multiplicity of sites removes the protection of names from any single institution's monopoly. The author places everyday documents and

intimate forms of address on a common narrative plane, although their social functions are distinct. The question of how the truth of a name travels across these forms is central to the novel's narration through multiple media.

The Conflict between Privacy and Public Memory

Meera resists the appropriation, without permission, of another person's body, love, weeping, letters, or silence. At the same time, the community seeks to establish collective presence through the public reading of names. These ambitions can conflict. The narrator does not erase the difficulty by staging an effortless consensus; the critical reading must recall the earlier experiment of being "confidentially present." Protected memory can exist only where public guardianship of names recognises the limits imposed by personal rights. To save a name by destroying its bearer's privacy would itself produce another injury.

Water, Fish, and Bridge: Nonhuman Participants

The eleventh rule treats the river, pond, drainage channel, flood, and water burial as places in which testimony occurs. Aruni's labour-centred rule and the movement of water compose a single social and ecological scene. The limits of documents cannot constrain the river's flow, while the construction of a bridge demands attention to the lives of workers and fish alike. This is an imaginative conflict between ownership of nature and responsibility in relation to it. Writing a rule does not calm the water; the renewed flood in subsequent chapters will become a practical test of this limitation.

Kabaddi's Rule of Breath and the Suggestion of Outer Space

The eighth rule—"Return before your breath runs out, but do not abandon your companion"—extends the action of kabaddi towards exile, power, wealth, and even the gleam of planets. The boundary line of the game can now be imagined beyond Earth. The novel inserts a discreet anticipation here: the sale of an "unnamed settlement" and the promise of another planet will enter its fictional world later. At this point, however, the future narrative remains foreshadowing in language, not an event already experienced. The critic must not treat a projected possibility as something that has actually occurred.

The Thirteenth Rule: The Deliberate Deferral of Forgiveness

The children disagree immediately over forgiveness: some demand punishment, while others reject forgiveness altogether. Ba calls forgiveness a long process of listening; ultimately a condition is written requiring the surrender of profit and the labour of attentive hearing. Rather than

producing a final judicial decision, the episode constructs a sequence of ethical responsibility. The future conduct of Batuknath or Lau may be examined against this standard. Forgiveness remains a proposed norm, not a reconciliation objectively completed within the story.

The Seal of the Root and the Thumbprints of Earth

Once the rules have been written on leaves, the question of a seal arises. Ananya wets a dry fibre from the stump and lays it upon the page's corner; the children make thumbprints with earth. In the absence of a state seal, collective labour and the living place provide symbolic authentication. This cannot be called actual constitutional validity: what the reader sees is a community's declaration of its own practice. The scent of soil on the thumbprints, the edges of fingernails, and the fibres give the written rules a bodily, material presence.

Copies That Begin with a Blank Page

Devika wants each copy of the rules to begin with a blank page so that a new village can first enter the names it has overlooked. This unusual device imagines a participatory text rather than an unchanging constitution. The written work retains an open space within which the next community may record its own story. It can be read as a restrained suggestion of metafiction, since the novel itself leaves readers room to listen instead of providing a wholly predetermined conclusion.

Collective Rules and the Question of Enforcement

Despite the attractive coherence of the fourteen rules, difficult questions of representation persist. The children, Ba, Meera, Aruni, Gop, and Satyavrat contribute different voices, but the text does not furnish a complete accounting of whether every affected family participates. State authority, the distribution of relief, and procedures for holding violators responsible also remain undecided. These limits should not merely be listed as weaknesses. They help explain why the narrative must submit the community's project to the test of the disasters still to come.

The Folk Song of the “Empty Chair” and the Coming Absence

Chapter 90 opens with a folk song imagining the consciousness of people filling the spaces between empty chairs. Yet its main action concerns the writing of rules upon leaves. In Chapter 91, “The Absence of the Tricksters,” empty seats become an explicit narrative event. The recurring correspondence between the opening song and the next chapter's theme is especially marked here. Music may be deliberately identifying a transition between chapters in this long work, or a song may have been shifted

during editing. Both possibilities should be tested against the songs that follow.

Critical Section 192 | Original Chapter 91 — The Absence of the Tricksters

A Dramatic Social Experiment with Absence

After the Constitution of Names, the assembly confronts a difficult question: should Batuknath, Chandrapal, Raghav, Lau, and Broom be invited? Ananya decides that the names of victims will remain at the centre of the gathering, while the actions of the accused will still be recorded even if they are absent. The narrative turns absence from a simple void into a deliberate means of rearranging who is present and who commands attention. This is the chapter's chief dramatic opposition: physical bodies are not on the platform, yet the shadow of their social influence remains.

Resisting the Temptation to Stage the Accused

Some young men want an open hearing of accusations; some women fear that victims will once again be punished by having to look at the faces of those who injured them. Not inviting the tricksters is therefore not the easy outcome of unanimous agreement but a tense choice between competing possibilities. The narrator forgoes the dramatic pleasure of public punishment in order to preserve time for accounts of suffering. Criticism must specify that exclusion from a community ceremony does not claim to abolish an accused person's right to be heard in a lawful court. What the narrative establishes is the symbolic centre of the gathering.

Satyavrat's Memory of the Courtroom

Satyavrat recalls the conventional naming of proceedings as "The State versus So-and-so." This time, the assembly proceeds under the names of those who have suffered. The story constructs opposing patterns of institutional caption and communal address. In the older arrangement, the accused is necessarily the prominent figure in the title of a case; in this scene, the injured person is remembered first. Satyavrat's act of taking notes marks a change in his focalisation, not an actual judicial ruling.

Parallel Scenes with Five Absent Men

The narrative cuts away from the assembly at Garh Narikel to Batuknath's room, Chandrapal's application, Raghav's signals, Lau's hotel, and Broom's advisory team. Each man, in his own fashion, expects an invitation or an opportunity to exercise control; each becomes unsettled when the gathering goes forward without him. Through this parallel editing, the reader receives information unavailable to any single participant inside the

meeting at that instant. Reading names aloud in one place and futile waiting in five distant rooms together form an ironic narrative structure.

Two Meanings of Silence: Raghav and the Victims

For Raghav, receiving no secret message represents a defeat in communication. For the families of victims, that same public silence creates respite from a threatening gaze. The narrator places an identical condition of silence within two opposed experiences. One character's silence may be a device for concealing wrongdoing; another's may be the self-protection of a witness. If this duality is lost, the novel's complex understanding of privacy disappears with it.

The Black-Edged Page: A Secondary Place for Accusations

A page with a black border is opened near the back of the register, headed "Those through whom names have been wounded." Actions, not people, are written down first: consuming dates, trafficking in bodies, traps laid through screens, disguising interests as charity, caste arrogance, and trading in memory. Only afterwards are individual names entered in smaller letters. The order of pages in the register itself becomes an ethical order of narration. The story depicts structural forms of injustice as larger than any one person implicated in them.

"The Wrong Large, the Wrongdoer Small": Maxim and Risk

Ba's instruction that the wrong should be written in large letters and the wrongdoer in smaller ones is a memorable maxim of the extended narrative. Its virtue is the recognition that removing one offender cannot remedy a system that remains unchanged. But the technique also entails a risk: the particular accused person's responsibility must not disappear from the process of accountability. The original text records both acts and names, so no complete erasure of personal identity occurs. Criticism must hold these competing implications in balance.

Absence Made Visible: The Movement of Shadows

After the last name is read, the shadows of the accused seem to creep from the black-edged page across the earth. The children place stones bearing names so that the shadows are pushed towards the edge. This marvel is not external testimony. It is the culmination of a visual structure: powers excluded from the platform still try to enter social life through their lingering traces. The progressive placement of stones makes the scene an act of collective resistance. The magical figure suggests temporary protection, not a victory achieved once and for all.

Redistributing the Right to Present Oneself

Meera asks whether refusing to invite the accused amounts to cowardice. Ananya replies that their names will be spoken when necessary, but that today victims will not measure their wounds through someone else's eyes. This declaration puts the earlier rule about privacy into direct social action. Victims no longer serve as objects of the camera, the account book, the platform, the litigant, or the philanthropic reformer. The narrative reassigns the spectator's position: who will be looked at, and who will be granted the right to look?

Why Does a Felled Tree Cast So Long a Shadow?

At the chapter's end, an unnaturally long shadow stretches westward from the stump. Ba calls it the shadow of the absent people. A severed stump could not cast such a shadow under ordinary physical conditions, so the episode creates a magical contradiction. Its narrative significance is the residual force of social exclusion and the power that survives it. The image poses the next chapter, "The Stump's Shadow," as a question rather than a settled explanation. Its ultimate cause remains open.

A Repeated Ending: Will the Wound Remain Central?

The meeting beside the Channa tree draws momentary courage from the exclusion of the accused, but the appearance of the dark shadow on the page means that fear has not entirely disappeared. This is a recurring narrative procedure: after every new social rule comes a new manifestation of older power. Immediately following the celebration of a solution, the narrator introduces an uncertain shadow. The reader is left wanting to know whether it is only a distortion of memory or a sign of an actual conflict still to come. That unresolved question makes the chapter boundary dramatic.

The Echo of Empty Chairs in the Songs

The closing song of Chapter 91, "The Empty Chair Speaks," clearly looks back upon the unfilled invitations and the shadows in this chapter. Its opening song, however, "A Hearing in the Stump's Shadow," prepares the atmosphere of the following chapter. The movement of the opening song towards the future and of the closing song back towards what has happened forms a two-layered musical structure requiring comparison across the whole sequence. This feature of the text should be identified by criticism, not silently erased in the name of correction.

Critical Section 193 | Original Chapter 92 — The Stump's Shadow

Entering Through an Unnatural Shadow

At the end of the preceding chapter, the question arose of an impossibly long shadow spreading from a felled stump; the present chapter makes that question its centre. Once the tree has been cut down, whose shadow remains? The narrator disrupts the ordinary proportions of matter so that the weight of a social absence becomes visible as physical magnitude. The reader cannot dispose of this shadow either as an everyday effect of the afternoon light or simply as a supernatural marvel. The persistence of the question supplies a causal thread across the chapter boundary: an unexplained sight determines the direction of the next act of narration.

The Stump's Ecological Body and Social Remains

The original body of the felled tree now consists of several kinds of remnant: the presence of leaves, a green point upon the roots, stones bearing names, and the children's assembly. Its shadow is no longer the shadow the tree once cast; it grows larger through collective effort, a history of repression, and the signs of people left outside justice. Nature is therefore not a static backdrop to this narrative. The stump's incomplete body allows the narrator to place two layers of time—the period before the cutting and the period after it—upon the same ground.

The Occasion of the Shadow, Not a Theory of Shadows

The original narrative offers several possible ways of seeing the shadow; people question its length, direction, and cause. The experienced voice of an elder and the perspective of children keeping watch give it different meanings. This distinction is essential to analysis: an interpretation uttered by a character is not a physical law authenticated by the narrator. To pronounce what has been left uncertain either a definite divine punishment or merely a psychological delusion would eliminate the reader's active part. The force of magical realism resides precisely in this suspended interpretation.

The Circular Place of Listening and the Shadow's Reach

In earlier sections of the story, communal hearings took place in a circle around the stump. The spreading shadow extends that confined place of gathering into subsequent scenes. The titular proposition that those who sit within its shade acquire larger ears expresses this altered social proportion. Narrative authority is determined not by an elevated platform but by the low ground around the stump. Through this spatial

transformation, the voices of excluded people, unnamed memories, and vacant seats are brought into relation with one another.

Name-Stones and the Shadow's Rival Memory

The stones bearing names are fixed objects intended to be read; the shadow shifts and moves. One aspires to permanence, the other embodies indistinctness. By keeping both within a single visual field, the narrator makes the difficulty of remembrance more acute. Writing a name on paper cannot contain the whole meaning of a life, just as collective fear does not invariably stop at a circle of stones. The narrative of the shadow supplements the stable archive: its work is to recall the ambiguous effects that remain beyond recorded history.

The Accused Men's Shadows and Invisible Power

In "The Absence of the Tricksters," five men had been removed from the centre of the assembly. Now the social lines they have left behind become visible. A person's physical absence does not terminate an economic network or ownership secured on paper. Through this device, the narrator preserves the accused men's history in the very place where the victims' new voices have begun to emerge. Opposing power need not depend upon personal presence: it survives through institutions, control of memory, and fear. The shadow gives this insight a concentrated visual form.

"The Stump's Shadow" and a Possible Transfer of Metaphor

The stump has lost its ordinary capacity to give shade, yet it remains a place around which people gather. This paradox forms a subtle basis for the novel's imagination of recovery: even after resources have been destroyed, relationships can create a new communal space. Literary transformation, however, is no substitute for actual reforestation or protection of water. The greater the narrative force given to a nonhuman voice, the more pressing becomes the question of how far concrete work to protect the stump and restore the grove has progressed.

A Pause in Narrative Time

In the preceding chapters, letters, public hearings, rules, and meetings followed one another rapidly. The shadow episode interrupts that pace; people consider the meaning of what they have seen. The ambiguity of the magical sight produces a prolonged tension in anticipation of a future crisis. A brief incident becomes a central metaphor and occupies the narrative time of a whole chapter. This deliberate slowing prepares a contrasting rhythm for the sudden and intense entry of the coming flood.

Warning Rather Than Accomplishment

After the celebration of the children's Constitution of Names, the shadow persists. In this sequence the narrative refuses to place a full stop after its own achievement. Establishing a moral rule and severing the hold of social fear are two distinct events; the first may occur while the second remains unfinished. The shadow is a creative image of the interval between them. Rather than declaring victory because laughter or a green point has appeared, criticism must identify the risks that still remain.

The Child's Old Pen and an Instrument of Wrongdoing

Batuknath's child brings an old pen used on petitions submitted by the father. Ananya asks, "Is the pen guilty, or the hand?" The pen is ultimately placed not alongside the name-stones but behind them on the earth. This small arrangement of objects distinguishes individual action, an instrument, and collective remembrance. The narrator neither convicts nor absolves the pen as an object. Its placement instead gives visible form to an ethical question that remains undecided.

Several Versions of the Shadow at a Distance

Chandrapal's paper bearing an incomplete name is placed at the shadow's outer edge; a dried leaf forms a counterfeit line where Raghav's message should be; the shadow enters Lau's glass room; and Broom's laptop goes dark and displays a wet deed of donation. These parallel incidents prevent the shadow from remaining an isolated accident of local light. It becomes a recurrent sign, differently experienced by several characters implicated in wrongdoing. Yet the original text provides no definite natural cause behind these distant apparitions.

From the Shadow's Warning to the Labour of Copying

When the smell of the river intensifies at midnight, Ananya calls for the registers to be tied up and copies made of the stones bearing names. Satyavrat provides old blank affidavits, Meera cuts cloth, Gop checks the copies, and Ira prepares a list for children living abroad. The uncertain premonition of the magical shadow thus becomes the practical labour of preserving paper, cloth, and names. The first concrete response to the approaching flood is already under way: the crisis is to be met through collective organisation, not by a miracle alone.

The Song of the Coming Flood: A Temporal Advance

The opening folk song of Original Chapter 92, "Greenery After the Flood," calls for raised platforms, seed boxes, boats, and safe houses. Yet the principal movement of the chapter remains suspended in uncertainty about the shadow; the actual crisis of rising water enters only in the next

chapter, “The Flood Again.” The song is already singing a future cycle of disaster. This repeated displacement in the relationship between song and narrative is an important question of textual correspondence, to be assessed against the sequence of songs as a whole.

From Shadow to Floodwater: From Apprehension to Event

The shadow spreads across the ground, whereas the water of the Kamala-Balan enters the lower parts of the village in the following chapter. This is more than a change of scenery: indefinite fear turns into the concrete work of managing a disaster. The measures designed to preserve names will be tested through actual soaking, displacement, and a crisis of relief. At this point, the shadow plays a preparatory visual role; it is the narrative bridge from anticipated danger to the occurrence of disaster.

The Limits of Interpretation: An Unproven Cause

The original narrative does not conclusively establish any single external cause for the shadow's impossible length. Criticism must therefore not call it either a miracle sent by a particular wrongdoer or a scientific forecast of a river flood. Such claims would exceed the original text and add an invention of the critic's own. The narrator's artistic accomplishment lies in keeping a scene charged with divergent meanings unresolved. The reader's continuing unease becomes, in itself, an aesthetic effect.

Critical Section 194 | Original Chapter 93 — The Flood Again

The Return of Seasonal Time and the Disruption of Linear Progress

The narrative has already shown a new phase marked by the Constitution of Names and the community school. The renewed flooding of the Kamala-Balan breaks the apparently straight line of that progress. The river repeats an earlier loss, but the characters' preparation is not what it was: they now have registers, stones bearing names, pledges to respect privacy, and rescue teams. The word "again" thus signifies not merely the recurrence of a natural phenomenon but a test of rules learned before. Narrative time can be cyclical even while the characters' memories accumulate knowledge in a linear fashion.

Disaster Begins with a Smell

Before the flood appears as visible water, it arrives through the smell of wet mud, broken bamboo, floating leaves, and an oppressive sky. This sequence exemplifies sensory foreshadowing: the reader apprehends danger through signals received by the body. Clouds, rain, water in the lanes, the sound of thatched roofs, and the filling of the pond subsequently accelerate the visual movement. The narrator employs sustained description of the environment not as decoration but as the temporal preparation of a disaster.

The Storehouse of Names and the Safety of Living Bodies

The children worry about protecting registers, leaves, stones, red thread, and names committed to memory. The danger of wet paper is real, but Aruni states the decisive priority: people first, documents afterwards, stones last. The children add that names will go with the people. The dialogue exposes a potential tension between the urgency of preserving memory and the primacy of living bodies. This matters because endangering the living in the very act of safeguarding the names of the absent would contradict the ethical centre of the narrative.

From Three Bundles to Four: An Account of Incomplete Testimony

Satyavrat makes three bundles, for names, silence, and wrongdoing, and then adds a fourth, called "Incomplete Hearings." This modest organisational change grants unfinished testimony a separate existence in the written account. Preserving an incomplete story, instead of claiming that every hearing has been completed, displays a form of procedural humility. If the flood carried away the pages, the unfinished voices might be lost first; this apprehension gives birth to the new category. The

arrangement of paper itself becomes a sign of memory's incomplete structure.

Devika and Digital Danger: Revising the Fast from Screens

The earlier fast from screens was not a vow to abandon every device in an emergency. During the flood, Devika and Nishant use mobile phones under restrictions: essential messages may be sent, but rumours must be checked. Chandrapal's memorial application reappears under the pretext of flood relief. The same medium offers the opposed possibilities of communal rescue and fraudulent donation. Here the plot avoids a simple rejection of technology: the decisive question is the policy governing use and the actions of the people who employ it.

Copies from the Page to the Voice

Gop Kumar is concerned with making documentary copies, while Ananya asks the children to memorise ten names each. Oral repetition becomes a second safeguard alongside the copying of paper. The novel's folk songs, recitation of names, and rhythms of breath in kabaddi acquire practical significance in this emergency. Yet memory can itself fail or forget, and the analysis must leave room for that vulnerability. A spoken copy does not replace a written one in full; it is another layer in a strategy for survival during disaster.

Life Across the Seasons and the Flood's Tangible Violence

The roofs of mud houses rattle; a calf is untethered; elderly people are led towards the school; grain is lifted onto raised platforms. Through these actions the flood ceases to be merely a symbolic court of justice. Labour, livestock, food, and the immediate needs of the old occupy narrative time. The writer places these everyday acts of relief beside the magical green point. A critical reading confined to supernatural recitations of names would miss the literary density of real displacement.

Kabaddi in the Water: A Change in the Game's Function

The old ghost urges the children to test their breath during the flood; pronouncing names becomes a kind of kabaddi played through the water. What had once been a ritual of remembrance now serves as an imaginative metaphor for rescue. Most importantly, the writer does not forget the organised rescue teams: each is arranged with children, registers, and memorised names. Nevertheless, a literary scene involving children entering floodwater amid the possible danger of crocodiles must not be mistaken for practical guidance on safe conduct. It is a scene of narrative tension.

A Test of Privacy in the Relief Queue

Meera brings a waterproof bag and tells a foreign research assistant to dry her hands first and take photographs later. In the shelter, families are first helped to dry themselves and given warm water; they are not compelled to pronounce their names. These actions put the privacy rules of the Constitution of Names into practice under emergency conditions. Principles concerning the potential commercial use of disaster photography become decisions made by characters. The narrative's ethics of listening passes from slogans into the order of care.

A Nonhuman Voice: The Flood Returns Something Too

The green point glimmers in the water, while the river's waves seem to sound like names. The narrator does not make the flood an exclusively destructive force; the river is imagined as capable of returning names from the past. The scene should not be turned into an external assertion that "the river really speaks." Rather, the storyteller brings the sound of water and social remembrance into a single auditory form. The boundary between the environmental voice of the disaster and human remembrance of the dead grows unstable.

The Renewed Activity of Profiteering Networks During Disaster

A wall collapses, donated supplies are swept away, a fraudulent relief account lights up, and a secret message declares "disaster is an opportunity." The structures associated with Chandrapal, Raghav, and Broom revive with the crisis. The writing of moral rules has not halted the movement of financial deception; opportunism searches for fresh forms. The flood is therefore not a punishment inflicted upon the wicked but a new condition of conflict. It means different things to those harmed by disaster and to the systems seeking profit from it.

The Foreshadowing of Crocodiles and the Crisis Ending

Just before dawn, a dark shape and shining eyes appear in the water. At first the shape resembles a piece of wood, then gradually suggests a living creature. Rather than making the crocodiles wholly visible at once, the writer filters their possible presence through the eye's uncertainty and doubt. The old ghost's words, "Now they too are returning," point towards the next chapter, "The Return of the Crocodiles." The flood narrative thus ends unfinished: the confrontation between an actual animal and a symbol of memory remains suspended until the coming scene.

Critical Section 195 | Original Chapter 94 — The Return of the Crocodiles

The First Sign: A Line Cut Across the Water

In the darkness of the flood, the crocodile first appears not as a clearly discernible body but as a long black line in the water. Those standing by the ghat feel a cold ripple against their calves before their eyes recognise the creature. The usual order of perception is reversed: touch warns sight in advance. The narrator produces fear not through snapping jaws or a spectacle of violence, but through the slow emergence of an unknown shape. Only after the animal is recognised does the group's response become more intense.

The Crocodile as Natural Animal and Symbolic Graha

The original story makes the crocodile at once an aquatic creature of the river and a guardian at the boundaries of memory. Ba makes clear that it would be mistaken to regard the river's animals simply as monsters. But the actual behaviour of natural crocodiles and the magical "returning of names" in the narrative are not facts of the same order. Narratological criticism must keep these levels distinct: fear and vigilance arise from the animal's body, while the metaphor raises questions of boundaries. A nonhuman narrative character is neither a moral offender nor humanity's ultimate saviour.

The Children's Perspective: Watch the Breath

At a moment of fear, Ananya tells the children to "watch the breath." The crocodiles swim in slow circles without immediately attacking. The earlier kabaddi exercises in breathing become a metaphor for reading the movement of aquatic animals. The scene foregrounds the children's collective focalisation: where the adults perceive only terror, the children seek meaning in the animals' movement and distance. This is a sensory arrangement within the fiction, not an instruction for safe contact with dangerous animals in real life.

Roots, Stones, and the Crocodiles' Circle

The largest crocodile pauses beside the submerged roots of the stump, while a stone bearing an unnamed name floats upon the water and is nudged back towards the bank by the animal's snout. Ordinary physical laws are suspended, giving the marvellous scene the unmistakable form of magical realism. The return of the stone is a narrative metaphor for the restoration of an identity belonging to the dead, not an account of actual

hydrology. The friction between the memorial stone's substantial weight and its impossible flotation heightens the force of the image.

The Old Boatman's Oral Memory

An elderly boatman says that crocodiles circle unclaimed bodies, and that when a name is given the water grows calm. Through this statement, local experience of life with the river enters the novel's collective remembrance. The narrator makes the boatman's words one voice among the events, without declaring them to be an externally verified scientific conclusion. How oral folklore gives figurative form to fear passed between generations is the question of narrative craft. The answer to how crocodiles should be seen emerges through several voices, not a single authoritative explanation.

Satyavrat Stops: A Subtle Change in Role

Satyavrat wishes to go farther into the water, but people stop him, and he obeys. Earlier, he had stopped because of institutional rules; now he responds to the warnings of those around him. The writer gives this unassuming action particular significance. Instead of a grand speech or a magical punishment, a small bodily choice becomes a credible sign of change in character. Nevertheless, it records one moment of conduct, not the complete correction of his institutional past.

Simultaneous Reflections of a Distant Network of Wrongdoing

Water marks on Lau's glass, Batuknath's softened paper, a crocodile-like mark on Chandrapal's screen, and Raghav's changing message: these four distant images are connected to the crocodiles' circular swimming at the ghat. The recurrence of informational effects across several places at the same moment constitutes a form of magical parallel editing. The reader witnesses the characters' mounting psychological pressure, but the scenes do not explain any actual law of electronic communication. The technique measures the vastness of a global alliance against the village's local memory.

Two Circles: Animals and Children

The crocodiles form an outer circle while the children maintain the rhythm of kabaddi within an inner one. This doubled circularity binds together boundaries, protection, and the possibility of confrontation. The circle of play had previously been the place where names were recited; now it becomes a visual counterpart to the aquatic animals' movement. The repeated shape is a compositional means of relating the narrative's different sites: the legal hearing, the circuit of letters, the public assembly, and the night of floodwater.

Freedom from Fear and the Limits of Romanticisation

The crocodiles do not attack and withdraw by dawn. People throw no stones at them, perform no worship, and simply clean the ghat. This is a symbolic picture of responsible coexistence. Yet crocodiles are powerful aquatic animals in nature, and the conduct described in fiction cannot be taken as evidence about real-world safety. The emancipatory perspective of the story and the biological risks involved operate on different levels. By maintaining that restraint, criticism preserves the metaphor's strength without idealising the animals.

A New Definition of "Boundary" and a Future Deal

Ananya describes the crocodile not as an enemy but as a boundary. At the chapter's end, news arrives from abroad of a proposal to acquire the flood-affected site of memory under the title "Water Security and Future Habitation." The question of boundaries at once becomes a question of land ownership and the trade in stories. Even the memory of the creature that has just appeared as a line is now to be subjected to attempted purchase. This contradiction opens the way for Lau's proposed transaction in the next chapter.

News of a Deal and Its Actual Narrative Distance

Ira receives the news, but the full terms of the company's documents are not made available at that moment. The narrator associates Lau, Broom, and Chandrapal with the network of accusations; the details of the actual proposal emerge in the next chapter. The ending of Chapter 94 must therefore be described not as a completed sale but as advance notice of a commercial offer. The report is a narrative hook for the approaching conflict, not a transaction already concluded.

The Song's Water Colours and a Question of Title Correspondence

The opening song asks its listeners to recognise crocodiles and protect the river, which accords with the chapter's central scene. Its closing song likewise repeats the return of the crocodiles and their message about boundaries. Yet the line "By day the water is muddy, at night black as oil" creates a symbolic atmosphere rather than a literal account of colour in an event. Here the relation among opening song, principal narrative, and closing song is comparatively more harmonious than in the earlier pattern of anticipatory songs. This difference makes a study of the entire song sequence especially necessary.

Critical Section 196 | Original Chapter 95 — Lau Kin-Hung's Final Deal

The Wrongdoer's Memory Before the Epigraph: An Unexpected Entry in the Textual Sequence

In the original text of this chapter, the title “Lau Kin-Hung's Final Deal” is followed by a memory of a wrong number in a refugee-camp register and humiliation in childhood, before the customary opening aphorism appears. Only then comes the maxim, “In the final deal, the price is not written down—the names are.” This sequence departs from the usual order of title, aphorism, and song. Placing memory immediately after the title grants the character's past the position of a moral preface; it is also an editorial irregularity in the textual form. Criticism must not erase the peculiarity by flattening the order.

The Origin of a Wound and Responsibility for Wrongdoing

Lau recalls the humiliation of being called by a wrong number on a refugee-camp list in childhood. The original text itself states clearly that an injury from the past does not excuse the choice to take away another person's name. This characterisation distinguishes the psychology of an offender from moral responsibility. In preceding chapters, Lau's glass, the sea, tall buildings, and profit without names were his principal signs. A specific childhood recollection now supplies an inward motive, but it does not turn him into an innocent hero.

Three Days of Flooding and the Delay of the Deal

After the crocodiles return, the flood continues to measure the village thresholds for three days. Meanwhile the children raise the stones, leaves, and registers onto tall bamboo platforms. The proposed deal is prepared inside a distant building. The narrator expands the duration of events in one place while compressing the process of planning in another. Such parallel arrangement of time highlights the difference between a community's struggle to survive and the readiness of global commerce. The village's bodies contend with floodwater before the papers of the offer reach them.

Many Advisers, One Meaning

In Lau's office, legal experts, philanthropic consultants, cultural intermediaries, and image advisers employ different words—assistance, a memory fund, a secure archive—yet their common objective is control. The practice of expressing a single intention through numerous courteous nouns gives the dialogue its irony. The characters' professional

designations matter: language announcing generous purposes is not detached from structures of profit. Through their convergent voices, the narrator exposes the varied but monotonous idiom of global institutions.

Philanthropy on Two Pages

The proposal promises flood relief, a school, repairs to the bridge, healthcare, women's security, and assistance to widows. In the fine-print annex appear provisions for copying records outside the community, control by an expert committee, the conversion of the children's independent watch into a volunteer programme, and joint management of the site. This is a two-layered documentary narrative, with a benevolent main text and small clauses transferring authority. The story does not destroy the paper by tearing it up; it makes its lines legible. The conflict concerns a concrete question of who possesses rights under the words, not metaphor alone.

"Anonymous Habitation": Advertising a Future Beyond Earth

One annex discusses the planet's crises and the possibility of safe settlements in the future. Selected gifted children, healthcare workers, data workers, and bearers of memory are promised places in distant habitations. This projection is not a space journey already accomplished in the present: it is the programmatic language of marketing. The story brings the promise into collision with the Constitution of Names and its injunction not to abandon one's companions. For people fighting a flood on Earth, is the offer to depart an escape, or another form of selective exclusion? The question is left open.

The Deal Arrives by Boat: The Dramatic Journey of an Object

The proposal is first represented through Raghav's invisible message, Batuknath's seal, Chandrapal's advice, Broom's philanthropic wording, and Lau's signature. The document, protected by plastic, reaches the flooded village by boat. The writer stages the passage of a document almost as though an independent character were making an entrance. A single sheet becomes the compressed body of an alliance stretching across the world, while the village mud contradicts its immaculate appearance.

"Let This Paper Listen First": Reversing the Reader's Position

Ananya does not immediately accept the proposal. She has the paper placed beneath the raised platform above the flowing water and begins a procedure of listening. Satyavrat reads line by line, while Meera, Devika, and Ba respond. The public reading subjects the document's self-proclaimed generosity to questions. A paper that had presumed to issue instructions must now hear the voices demanding accountability. Through

this reversal of roles, the writer turns the communal scene into an active theatrical space.

From Children's Watch to "Trained Volunteers": The Politics of Naming

Under the terms of the deal, the children's independent watch is to be called a body of "trained volunteers." Ba warns that changing the name may change the nature of the watch itself. Language here is not an ornament but an instrument for arranging rights. A new designation appears to confer respect, yet placing leadership under external training makes institutional control possible. The writer conceals a larger story of power being transferred within a seemingly minor administrative title.

The Reply Is a Recitation of Names, Not Silence

Rather than providing an immediate written response, Ananya initiates the recitation of names: Sarayu, Ujjwal, bridge workers, a woman from the hospital, a young man harmed by a screen-based fraud, unnamed people, and suppressed memories of lives. The list centres persons who suffered losses, not money as the measure of value. The village neither throws away nor burns the letter; it turns the obligation to listen back upon its senders. The dramatic refusal matters, but the original text does not say that the offer has been definitively rejected as a legal matter. Ananya herself enters "Not declared rejected" in the register.

Lau's Response: A Limited Stirring of Decision

In the distant office, one corner of the paper appears wet. Lau realises that the people are not asking for a price, and remarks that they do not wish to abandon their Earth. A magical simultaneity connects the village's reading of names to Lau's glass building. Yet no completed act establishes that Lau has surrendered the money, closed the company, recognised land rights, or paid compensation. A clear distance must be maintained between movement in a character's understanding and a legal or material outcome.

Batuknath Arrives Empty-Handed

In the final scene, Batuknath stands ankle-deep in floodwater. This time he does not put trust papers, titles, or vehicles before him; he asks only to be allowed one night to listen to the names. His modest change continues the question raised by Tarini in Chapter 80 and the waiting occasioned by his absence in Chapter 91. Public forgiveness and restitution are not yet complete. The chapter itself announces that the following night will test "forgiveness that came late."

The Word “Final” and the Continuation of Conflict

The title “Final Deal” suggests completion, yet the plot does not close the offer with a clear acceptance or rejection. Instead, Batuknath's hearing, Lau's power of control, and the plans for anonymous habitation remain questions for the next chapter. “Final” may be understood as the greatest ambition of the trade or its figurative last move; one cannot infer that a definitively executed transaction has taken place. The concluding song likewise points towards the next test of belated forgiveness.

The Opening Song of Forgiveness and a Test Still to Come

The opening folk song of Chapter 95 is called “Amendment Alongside Late Forgiveness,” although much of the main narrative concerns Lau's proposed deal and Batuknath seeks permission to be heard only at the end. The song anticipates the questions of forgiveness, reform, and restitution in the following stage. Once again, the opening song's time runs ahead of the principal events. The critical conclusion is not that the song was certainly placed incorrectly; rather, the temporal interval between song and scene demands the reader's attention, especially when compared with the recurring pattern across Chapters 88–95.

Critical Section 197 | Original Chapter 96 — Batuknath's Belated Apology

A Late Arrival: The Temporal Gap After the Final Deal

Chapter 95's closing scene shows Batuknath standing empty-handed in floodwater and asking for one night in which to listen to the names. Chapter 96 says that he arrived alone on the third day after calm returned. No direct chronological link is supplied between these statements. The narrative does not explain whether the earlier scene was an initial arrival and the later one a formal return, or whether the same moment has been recounted under a new time marker. It would be inappropriate to silently erase this discrepancy. On the level of narration, this is a distinct, unresolved temporal joint: the decision to repent is intimated first, and the practical exercise of repentance begins in a second scene. Despite the chronological uncertainty, the reader's ethical expectation persists: what will the man who has come now do?

Shedding the Outer Costume of Prestige

The earlier Batuknath appeared surrounded by courtrooms, verandas, weighty books, assistants and prestige. Here there is no flag on his vehicle, no lawyer at his side, and dust covers his feet. The narrator changes not merely the man's clothes but the visual language of authority. A figure once elevated on a high veranda becomes a listener seated at the edge of the stump. The reader observes a change, but simplicity of dress must not be taken as proof of official innocence. The visual reduction places his arrogance in question, while the history of earlier cases, workers, women's dignity and the appropriation of names remains untouched. This balance in the handling of the scene is one of the chapter's principal achievements.

The Return of the Family Question in Memory

In Chapter 80, Tarini had asked directly: had he saved justice, or his profession? In this chapter Batuknath is again haunted by fear in his family's eyes; he hears his grandson asking which side he had been on. The naming of children and grandchildren, and their temporal relationships, belong to different episodes. The grandson's question should not be treated as a verbatim repetition of Tarini's words. Through the presence of several generations, the narrative intensifies the structural pressure of inheritance. A question addressed by a family member penetrates more deeply than an indictment, because domestic listeners are now in a position to reject a self-image built on status, lineage and wealth. Family remorse, nevertheless, does not take the place of restitution.

Satyavrat's Reply: Refusing the Right to Grant Forgiveness

Batuknath first tells Satyavrat Mehta that he has come to ask for forgiveness. Satyavrat replies: not from me, but from all those whose names are being read. This brief exchange displaces the judicial centre of the story. Asking an experienced legal professional for personal pardon could easily have become a settlement between men of authority. Satyavrat withdraws his own claim to adjudicate as intermediary. Consequently, the voices of Ananya, Ba and the families move into the foreground. The authority to forgive cannot be conveniently deposited with any one individual or institution. Instead of making this discipline into a comforting emotional tableau, the narrative situates it within the discomfort of communal listening.

Ananya's Question: From Pronouns to Names

When Batuknath says, “I am guilty,” Ananya immediately asks, “Towards whom?” A general declaration such as “towards everyone” is not critically sufficient. Her question makes him identify the actual acts that constituted his wrongdoing: turning names into cases rather than recognising human beings; covering crimes through procedure; using tradition as a shield; and making justice into a profession. The narrator advances the dialogue from moral adjectives to the description of acts. Naming these acts is not the climax of the offender's performance; it is an exercise in making memory specific. A child's single question transforms an adult's prepared apology into a more factual statement.

Hearing Dates Transformed into Sound: The Violence of Procedure

As Batuknath listens to the names of Sarayu, Munna Paswan, invisible labourers, humiliated women and young victims of fraud, he remembers the familiar sound of “the next date.” In court, a hearing date had been a legal instrument; during the night of recitation it emerges as an interval of lives kept in suspension. By shifting attention from figures in a ledger to human names, the narrator changes the experience of time. Years of delay are no longer entries on paper, but the destruction of time actually lived by individuals and families. This acoustic recontextualisation makes the consequences of earlier courtroom scenes present without replaying them directly. Yet no actual resolution of those cases is shown here.

The Duration of Listening: Punishment and Narrative Pace

The reading of names continues throughout the night. The narrator does not recount the complete history of every name again; selected names and the responses to them gather manifold suffering into a compressed sequence. There is a difference between the completeness of the night and the selectivity of its narration. At first Batuknath constructs a technical

defence against each name. By the third watch his defences are exhausted, but the names are not. The pace gradually changes from initial self-protection to sustained hearing and then self-acknowledgement. The value of this progression lies in the communal repetition of names. No miraculous command instantly purifies his conscience.

The Response "Present" and the Control of Speech

The circle reads out names, and everyone replies, "Present." For a long time Batuknath is not permitted to become the principal speaker: he has been assigned the place of a listener. Throughout the novel, kabaddi has undergone transformations into a discipline of breath and the circulation of names. Here it becomes the auditory rhythm of a stationary gathering. The unilateral privilege of dialogue is removed; communal calling takes the place of the offender's speech. This does not mean that the assembly becomes the formal equivalent of a court. It is a scene in which the hierarchy of words is reversed within the fictional world. The reader, too, attends not to Batuknath's eloquence but to the difficulty of his listening.

Ba: Distinguishing Compassion, Acknowledgement and Forgiveness

At dawn, Ba looks at Batuknath, but the narrator makes clear that her look contains no effortless pity; it expresses a stern acknowledgement. The distinction matters. The beginning of an admission of wrongdoing may be acknowledged without forgiveness being automatically conferred. Between offering water, asking him to rise and requiring him to remain seated through the night, Ba remains the centre of discipline. The characters' sympathy does not become a washing away of evidence. Compared with the more openly remorseful scenes elsewhere in the novel, such an undramatic response exhibits greater ethical patience.

Forgiveness Is a Practice, Not a Verdict: An Open Ending

Ananya tells Batuknath: "Forgiveness is not a verdict. It is a practice. Tomorrow the names will be read again. Come." Her reply deliberately forestalls the conventional climax of tears, pardon and embrace. The character's new condition is not a guaranteed redemption, but an obligation to be present regularly. One night's duration cannot compensate for the harm of a lifetime. The title, "Batuknath's Belated Apology," announces the arrival of forgiveness, while the main narrative offers not the gift of pardon but its difficult beginning. This tension between title and event needs to be read explicitly.

The Site of Atonement Beside the Flood

The chapter unfolds amid wet earth after the flood, the edge of the stump, lamps upon the raised platform and stones bearing names. Batuknath's

private self-examination takes place on the public ground of disaster. The smell of water connects him with the past, but the river is not established as a human judge of justice. Natural substances provide a context for experience. Because the suffering inflicted by flood and by legal delay is present together, the scene extends beyond individual self-recognition towards labour, rescue and communal obligation.

The Ledger at the Chapter's End: A Transition from Batuknath to Chandrapal

After Batuknath's night, the scene cuts to Chandrapal's ledger. In place of credits, debits and percentages, the word "medium" shines, while the screen answers, "mule." This final turn is more than notice of the following chapter: it introduces a new metaphor of crime. Both Batuknath's delayed procedures and Chandrapal's circulation of money might invite the defence, "I was only an instrument." The novel prepares to examine that defence in the next section. The account of a transformed consciousness therefore remains inseparable from the question of systemic responsibility.

The Placement of the Folk Song: Why Does the Account Come First?

Chapter 96 opens with a folk song, "Your Own Account, Your Own Life," about financial caution, unfamiliar money and identity. Yet the principal event is Batuknath's listening; the metaphor of an account emerges chiefly in the final transition and is developed in Chapter 97. The song's subject thus runs a step ahead of the events. The closing song revisits the belated apology, the ledger of delays and unfinished repentance. The difference between anticipatory opening and retrospective ending is significant when assessing the reader's sense of narrative pace.

The Scene's Limits: Neither Settlement of Cases nor Compensation

The narrator creates a powerful communal scene for Batuknath's listening, but does not show him returning money to affected families, reopening cases, correcting written lists or relinquishing institutional ownership. Atonement can become a credible beginning for the character, not proof of a result. Narratologically, it is appropriate for the scene to leave the reader in precisely this unfinished state: the light of dawn may offer relief, but the narrative does not declare a conclusion. The following chapter's metaphor of the criminal "medium" broadens the same incompleteness.

Critical Section 198 | Original Chapter 97 — Chandrapal's Mule Account

Introducing the Term: Expanding the Meaning of "Mule Account"

The chapter's title turns a technical expression from financial crime into a figure of the character's self-understanding. A mule account is ordinarily an account used to move money on another person's behalf; the narrative makes it a metaphor for Chandrapal's life. He had imagined that opening accounts was an exercise of his own power, only to discover that he, too, had been used as an intermediary. The reversal exposes a fracture in his self-respect. Yet the existence of concealed operators does not erase his personal responsibility. To call himself an "instrument" spreads the lines of culpability across several levels; it is not evidence of innocence.

The First School Day: A Flashback to the Humiliation of a Mispronounced Name

Before the chapter's formal title, Chandrapal remembers a teacher misreading his name during school attendance and the class laughing. Later the main account returns to his childhood, social ridicule and wish to have his name written in large letters. This flashback gives the offender a psychological genealogy in which someone whose own name was humiliated became a man who reduced other people's names to numbers. The text itself, however, says that memory does not make him innocent; it strips away his self-deception. The critical distinction between a biographical explanation and a moral defence is preserved.

"Chandu–Channu–Chandru": Variants in Forms of Address

Chapter 74 uses "Chandu" as a childhood name within the family; Chapter 81 offers "Channu"; and Chapter 97 remembers other forms of address, including "Chandru." Different people may of course have used different names. The text, however, does not usually organise the differences into a clear account of distinct social forms of address. It would therefore be premature to declare them certainly erroneous, but equally unwarranted to assume a self-evident consistency. In a chapter centred on the instability of names, such variants might become meaningful symbols or remain a problem of editorial continuity.

The Reversal of Self-Authority: From Owner to Intermediary

Chandrapal's inner history describes the influence he acquired through status, certificates, contacts and partnerships. When he understands himself as a mule account, the relation is reversed: a person accustomed to

issuing orders experiences himself as an instrument that carries them. Yet an exploiter's experience of being exploited does not put him in the position of the families he harmed. The reader should remain alert to this danger. Chandrapal's humiliation is an independent psychological event on the narrative plane, whereas digital fraud and the commerce in the dead's mourning constitute real losses for those who endured them.

The River of Linked Accounts: A Metaphor Gradually Extended

Accounts, percentages, commissions and networks have been recurring signs since Chapter 74. In Chapter 97 the network becomes a river, and Chandrapal experiences himself as soil caught in its current. The earlier imagery of water-burial now accommodates financial circulation. Accounts floating on water, little crocodiles formed from accounts and chewing names, and a room surrounded by floodwater are intensified transformations within the character's inward vision. Distinguishing these images from literal events involving actual bank accounts preserves the novel's magical metaphor.

The Curse of Percentages: Accounting and Writing

In Chapter 81 Chandrapal's pen wrote “percentage” where a name should have been; in Chapter 97, after his titles fall away, he hears the word “mule.” The chapters present separate stages of the same affliction. The first scene is an incapacity to write a person's identity; the second recognises his own intermediary role in crime. Writing is initially blocked; later he thinks of taking his ledger to the public watch. The change is not a magical cure accomplished by writing. It only suggests a movement from the lies of self-defence towards confronting the documentary record.

A Degree from Meerut and the Story of Social Humiliation

Chandrapal associates long-standing resentment with his cheap degree and the social doors that remained closed to him. He had come to believe that, since society deceived people, deceiving society was cleverness. The narrator traces the growth of this self-legitimating argument: cleverness becomes livelihood, livelihood brokerage, brokerage crime and crime organised commerce. Each succeeding step appears as a choice, not an unavoidable decree of fate. The narrative acknowledges the impulse to locate the seed of wrongdoing in social disdain, but does not turn the disrespect he experienced into a licence to sell the grief of thousands.

The Hierarchy of Address: Sahib, Sir, Broker

People had called Chandrapal “Batra Sahib” and “Sir”; officials answered his calls, and criminals touched his feet. His social influence was built

through this order of address. When he himself becomes an account, the honorific language is emptied of significance. The narrator depicts the collapse of prestige through solitary realisation, not through arrest or public exposure. But a private breakdown is not verified social change. The fragmented name on a screen and the power still exercised in society belong to distinct levels; the reader should not mistake one for the other.

The Body Made into a Conduit: The Meaning of Magical Accounting

Floating accounts and sheets of water marked "through" or "intermediary" surround Chandrapal's room in the flood. The factual machinery of files takes material form. What had been invisible routes for money in the outside world now become an encirclement of his body. The scene relies upon a close focalisation: the reader witnesses Chandrapal's fear and disintegration, but cannot conclude that every other character actually saw accounts floating in the water. The magical image occupies a shared terrain between a conscience burdened with crime and the narrator's power of metaphor.

An Unfinished Letter to Raghav

Chandrapal opens Raghav's number and first types, "Close the account," then deletes it. He next types, "Whose account was it?" and deletes that as well. His final sentence, "I was an intermediary, but I was not innocent," signals a movement in language from defence towards acknowledgement. Before he can send the message, the screen stops and the letters become leaves clinging to it. The interruption of transmission matters: public responsibility cannot be fulfilled simply by sending a message. One must appear in person and stand behind what it means.

The Layers of Crime and the Unnamed Principal Owner

The chapter identifies several roles: the person through whom money passed, the one who changed lists, the one who issued orders and the person who profited from a distance. Chandrapal wants to call himself merely an intermediary, but eventually admits he was not innocent. The narrative force of that admission lies in keeping the different levels of responsibility distinct. Still, the identities of the true controllers, the precise routes of funds, the reconciliation of victims' names with accounts and the public presentation of evidence are not completed here. The story opens up the mule-account metaphor; it does not finish a criminal audit.

The Road to the Village: An Unverified Resolve to Atone

At dawn Chandrapal ties his ledger and written pages in a cloth and decides to travel to the place where names are kept under watch. The story does not yet show him arriving at the village and opening the accounts

before the actual victims. The closing proposal—to write his entire name but also record the percentages—suggests a serious desire to indict himself. Whether that desire becomes a cunning request for release through confession or a difficult disclosure remains dependent on the next scene. To say that "he confessed everything" would impose a result that the narrative has not supplied.

Encirclement and Control: The Flood as an External Backdrop

The village faced the crisis of the river flood, and water rises behind Chandrapal's own window. The correspondence between the external flood and the flow of money through accounts creates a multilayered water metaphor. A person becomes an account, accounts become crocodiles, and crocodiles chew up names: this rapid sequence of images extends the metaphor of the novel's title. There is nevertheless a danger in forcing the symbolism. Not every account is literally an aquatic creature. Their resemblance is a critical means of interpretation, not a definitive statement of the story world's physical laws.

The Folk Song Again Faces the Next Story: A Tale of Signals

Chapter 97 opens with the folk song "Hope of a Message on a Leaf," giving the signal and clouds of vanishing letters an anticipatory meaning of hope. Its main scene concerns Chandrapal's accounts, while Chapter 98 actually centres on Raghav's last message. Once again, the song selects a topic a step farther ahead in narrative time. The closing song gathers the metaphor of a life turned into a mule and the intermediary role in crime. As with the opening financial song in Chapter 96, the paratextual song and the main narrative move in different temporal directions.

The Limits of Character Analysis: Do Not Aestheticise Guilt

Chandrapal's childhood, humiliation, tears, name caught in the roots and dreams of crocodiles draw the reader close to his inner world. Such intimate focalisation is a significant literary achievement, yet its attraction risks casting the victims' testimony into shadow. A successful reading must explain the offender's psychology without inadvertently raising him to moral equivalence with those he harmed. Earlier chapters on registers, public accounts and the consent of families provide the grounds on which this critical limit can be maintained.

Critical Section 199 | Original Chapter 98 — Raghav's Final Message

The Finality Promised by the Title and the Chapter's Unfinished Answer

The title “Raghav's Final Message” creates the expectation of a decisive last statement. The story eventually arrives at a message transformed into a leaf, but the additional words on the leaf, “The debt of listening remains,” reopen its narrative finality. This last message is not proved to be the criminal network's last communication; nor is it established that no further message will arrive. The tension between the event announced by a title and the space left open by the narrator is a recurring method in the novel. Here finality belongs to the message's refusal to be erased, not to the completion of moral judgement.

The Erased Voice of His Mother: An Ethical Reversal in Personal Flashback

Before the chapter's main text, Raghav recalls the pain of accidentally deleting a recording of his mother's final voice. This autobiographical glimpse is significant: the offender knows from experience what it means to lose another person's message. Yet he continued deliberately to erase other people's appeals, traces of wrongdoing and signs of threats. Personal loss and public wrongdoing are connected by a single visible object: the deleted message. His mother's loss, however, was not an inevitable cause of his later crimes. The recollection sharpens the contradiction in his ethical life.

Five Devices and the Room of Distributed Power

Five illuminated devices stand in Raghav's room, each showing locks, times, pseudonyms, donation accounts and contacts abroad. Through this inventory the narrator supplies not an abstract account of digital power but a material setting for it. The heat of the devices, their humming and the whirl of messages become sensory elements of the narrative. Everything looks orderly on the outside while the meanings of relationships are collapsing within. The multiplicity of five screens displays personal control, although the reader knows that actual communication has become obstructed. The contrast is between an abundance of instruments and a shortage of meaningful listening.

Relations in Code and the Absence of Real People

Raghav's secure groups bear labels such as “donation,” “heritage,” “clean-up,” “trust” and “archive.” Behind every signifier are real people, but the criminal network turns them into functional categories instead of recognising their identities. A parallel transformation appears in Chapter 97, where accounts displace names. Code narrows the characters' focalisation: they see neither companions nor victims nor adversaries, but routes and points of access. By listing these artificial names, the narrator makes the reader imagine the people who are absent. The obscurity of the coded labels is, however, deliberately retained.

Secret Writing in Childhood: The Origins of a Professional Habit

Raghav remembers secret writing made with lemon juice, letters brought to visibility by the heat of fire, and his father's advice that he should learn to keep secrets. This flashback traces his inclination towards coded language back into social education. But the narrative establishes a necessary distinction: some secrets protect human dignity, while others shield crime. The same technique can have two ethical uses. To condemn secrecy as inherently guilty would therefore simplify the creative argument of the episode. The wrong lies in the chosen concealment that enables the theft of other people's names.

The Automatic Return of the Nickname “Signal”

Raghav tries to write his name as “Raghav Somani,” but the screen displays “Raghav Signal Somani.” He deletes the nickname, only for the letters to reappear. The narrator shows the collapse of the illusion that one can control a digital identity independently and completely. A nickname once awarded for ingenuity has become a mark of crime. This magical occurrence in the spelling of a name is not a legal prohibition on changing one's name in the outside world; it is a form of the character's psychological refusal and the story's linguistic resistance. Its force depends on maintaining the different levels of narration.

Four Failed Transmissions: A Negative Sequence of Contact

Raghav attempts to send separate statements to Chandrapal, Batuknath, Lau and Broom. Each statement exposes one part of the criminal system: an account, delay, profit, or bodies hidden behind donations. None of the messages is shown reaching its addressee. The four failures form a structure of repetition in which the habit of ceaseless communication is turned against itself, leaving the speaker to hear his own words. To assume that all four adversaries received the information would destroy the novel's essential contrast. The failed sending is itself the event, not a successful exchange of intelligence.

Deleted Messages Becoming Leaves: The Magical Return of the Archive

In an inner vision of a dark room, thousands of erased messages turn into hanging leaves. Later Raghav's particular sentence is seen taking the form of a green leaf and arriving at the edge of the Channa stump. The two leaf-images are connected, but their modes differ: the first is situated in the offender's consciousness; the second is an object seen by children in the village. The narrator turns digital signs into living matter. Within the story world this is an instance of magical realism; it would be a mistake to present it to the reader as a factual recovery from a server or as a technical forensic report.

"The Account Is Not Closed, the Soul Is Open": The Unfinished Grammar of the Sentence

A particular message refuses deletion: "The account is not closed, the soul is open." Its two clauses point towards opposing temporal conditions. The financial account remains active, while an inner opening is claimed to have taken place. This irony is central to the chapter. Raghav declares an opening of conscience, yet the economic infrastructure of crime has not been shut down. The narrator does not remove this inequality; the words become fixed upon a leaf of the Channa stump. The clearer the gap between inward acknowledgement and the ending of an external criminal arrangement, the more exacting the ethical scrutiny becomes.

Devika, Meera and Ba: A Collective Challenge to Interpretation

After seeing the leaf upon the stump, Ba asks the stern question of a court of names. Meera says that admission without accountability remains incomplete; Devika reminds everyone how difficult it is to reveal oneself to those injured by codes. Three social readings of a single leaf are presented. The village does not accept the meaning of inner disclosure that Raghav constructed in his own message as the only meaning. The narrator does not immediately yield to sympathy. The differing voices of the women test the announcement of self-reform against difficult lived experience.

The Stone Called "Waiting": Judgement Deferred

Ananya places a stone beneath the leaf and names it "Waiting." Earlier stones had borne the names of the dead; here the stone signals the expectation of an offender's unfinished testimony. This event extends the semantic family of the name-stones without equating the standing of the dead and the accused. The community accepts the leaf into its midst, but does not turn it into a certificate of forgiveness. A future-directed narrative

time becomes fixed in the name of this object. Someone may come and say something; what result will follow nevertheless remains unknown.

Writing Directly on Paper: A Medium After Code

Raghav finally sits down to write on ordinary paper that his silence was a crime. Moving from code, encryption and ephemeral messages to writing on plain paper visibly marks a new stage. Yet the recipient of this paper, its public presentation and its permanent preservation are not fully developed in the main narrative. The reader can understand that plain paper opens a direction towards responsibility without mistaking it for a public punishment or a completed testimony. The narrator articulates this interval through Satyavrat's response.

The Doorway to Testimony: Satyavrat's Statement and His Self-Inclusion

After reading the leaf, Satyavrat says: "This is not testimony, but the doorway to testimony. The door is open; entering remains." Without laborious explanation, this distinguishes testimony from an advance sign of testimony. Ananya asks who will testify. Satyavrat replies: those who failed to speak in time should do so first—"myself included." That final inclusion shifts the chapter's point of attention from Raghav towards Satyavrat. The next chapter's new act is prepared directly through dialogue, not imposed by an order from an external narrator.

The Song's "People Present in Silence" and the Ground of Listening

Chapter 98 opens with a folk song honouring people present in silence, peaceful companionship and the dignity of a safe place. In the principal narrative, Raghav struggles with his own covert silence and his offence of deleting messages. The same word, "silence," thus bears two opposing ethical meanings: the protective silence of victims and the evidence-destroying silence of an accused person. The closing song gathers the final message that has adhered to the leaf. Ignoring this distinction would mistakenly place the tender silence of the folk song and Raghav's deceptive silence in the same category.

The Limits of Change from Afar: Legal Admission versus a Leaf

Messages remain stuck on Raghav's devices; a leaf reaches the village; Satyavrat calls it a doorway to testimony. But there has yet been no verification of digital logs, courtroom deposition, compensation for harm or approval by affected people. The moral truth of a narrative and the status of a legal document are not identical. The leaf's magical arrival may become the centre of the reader's emotional response, but the examination

of public responsibility remains ahead. This incompleteness keeps the novel from becoming an easy story in which sin is simply washed away.

Critical Section 200 | Original Chapter 99 — Satyavrat Mehta's Testimony

The Directness of the Title and a New First-Person Voice

In the preceding chapters, stones bearing names, magical leaves, accounts and shadows were major narrative signs. Chapter 99 begins with the direct title "Satyavrat Mehta's Testimony." The character himself writes his name, without an official designation, at the head of his testimony. The centre shifts from external symbols of listening towards first-person responsibility. Although the narrator arranges the scene in the third person, Satyavrat's "I" can be clearly heard in the portions of written testimony. This alteration in narrative level narrows the distance between the character and his evidence, but testimony does not thereby become a complete public judgement.

A Page Folded Three Times: Preliminary Gestures Towards Writing

Before the chapter's main opening, we are told that Satyavrat folded his sheet of paper three times. He feared that writing the truth would crack the prestige of his office, friendships and decisions. Ananya's practice of striking out a word in the register and replacing it with the correct one encourages him. The threefold folding of the paper becomes a small metaphor for delayed decision. His inward hesitation arrests the narrative movement, yet precisely this pause gives weight to the testimony to come. Had he made a fearless confession in his first sentence, the ethical cost of the act would have remained invisible.

Plain Paper in Place of an Affidavit

Satyavrat has old affidavits, a notebook and a fountain pen in his bag. For his testimony, he chooses an unmarked white sheet without an official heading or seal. The symbols of his public office are present but not employed. The change dramatically reverses his understanding of authorial authority. His old signature carried institutional credibility; here he must speak as an ordinary human being before those who suffered. The critical qualification is that an informal page is not automatically a substitute for a legally constituted affidavit. It is a symbolic document within the story's ethical order.

A Sequence of Events in the Testimony: Four Failures of the Record

In his statement Satyavrat identifies the removal of bridge workers' names from a list, the trade in breath at the hospital, households ruined by digital fraud and the conversion of women's privacy into accusations against their character. These four episodes briefly return to different narrative strands

of the novel. The narrator does not rewrite hundreds of earlier events as fully expanded scenes; he creates a selected list within the character's admission. Through this summary-like return, the reader recognises a single silent centre connecting separate paths: the failure of a person holding office to speak at the proper time.

"The Procedure Is Ongoing": A Wrong Committed Through Time

The workers' list had been altered, and Satyavrat had written, "The procedure is ongoing." While the procedure kept going, the bodies decayed. The force of this contrast lies in its dramatic comparison of time. Institutional present tense proceeds indefinitely, while human biological time comes to an end. Linguistic parallelism sharpens the disparity. A delay in court or office is not merely one error recorded against a date; it is an invisible expenditure of lived time. Satyavrat makes his earlier silence into an event. His testimony does not, however, fully specify whose legal case will be reopened, or when.

A Figure Shrinking in Stature: The Ethical Arithmetic of Focalisation

The story says that the more Satyavrat writes, the smaller his body appears. This is not a statement that his physical measurements have actually diminished; it is a dramatic proportion created by the narrator. Previously, when he rose in court, everyone fell silent. Here he sits among children and writes down his own faults. The change in visual proportion signifies a change in power. He does not become a hero; instead, he descends from the height of office to a common human level. The aesthetic reversal ensures that the confession appears as the beginning of duty rather than a self-congratulatory autobiography.

Ba: Late Testimony and the Time of Seeds

Ba does not speak, but the description of her gaze introduces the comparison of a seed that has germinated late. Such a seed may not give a large yield, but the truth of the seed may survive. The image connects with Batuknath's belated apology in an earlier chapter. In both places, delay increases the damage, yet it is not necessary to discard every change undertaken after the delay. It would nonetheless be premature to assert that the seed has already borne fruit. The character's future-oriented ethics is established within the unfinished time of cultivation.

"The Caste System of Silence": The Creation of a New Phrase

Ananya writes "the caste system of silence." Two structures of power become visible together in this compound phrase: hierarchies based on birth, and hierarchies deciding whose voice a gathering will hear and whose it will suppress. It is a concentrated naming of the novel's social

experience. It must not, however, be pronounced an unrestricted sociological conclusion. Its effect arises in a specific scene, through Satyavrat's silence and the long-suppressed voice of an elderly woman leatherworker. The phrase is most accurately used in criticism when its origin remains tied to this particular moment in the child's register.

"In the Middle": Recording Victims and Silent Beneficiaries Together

When the question arises where the page of testimony should be placed, Ananya specifies that it must be kept not after all the names, but among them. The spatial arrangement offers an exceptionally subtle scene of social responsibility. Had the letter been placed at the end, it could have become a sympathetic epilogue. Placed in the middle, the role of office-holders' silence remains present whenever the victims' stories are read. The position of an object becomes part of the story's thought. This middle space does not elevate the offender's name above the victims; it keeps the page of responsibility inseparable from their testimony.

A Leaf Among Stones: The Resonance of Earlier Characters

Satyavrat's page is placed among the stones arranged in a circle. The wind makes it flutter, and then it settles. Nearby are Raghav's leaf-message, Chandrapal's unfinished name, the memory of Batuknath's listening and Lau's wet document of negotiation. Through the parallel editing of objects, earlier chapters are gathered into one scene. The novel makes the narratives of separate offenders mutually accountable without requiring them to meet directly. The material differences among paper, leaf, stone, water and ash make the gathering a multi-object archive of memory.

A New Turn in the Question of the Elephant and the Crocodile

After the testimony, the old ghost turns the narrative towards the elephant-and-crocodile story. The allusion reminds the reader that hearing inward truth is not enough: the entire structure of entrapment must be examined again. In Chapter 82 the elephant and crocodile within had become a collective scene; in Chapter 94 actual crocodiles returned in the water as teachers of limits. The question now reaches the jaws of institutions and silence. This is not one stable meaning of a single symbol, but a narrative function changing with circumstances. Rather than giving the symbol its final definition, the story opens a route towards its next use.

Writing and Hearing: First-Person Responsibility

Satyavrat writes the page in his own hand; Ananya reads it, and the families listen among themselves. Writer, reader and affected people are not the same. Preserving the distance between these three roles is one of the narrative's achievements. In his earlier judicial life, the officer's written

decision had been the final form of an utterance; here the page awaits communal reading and questioning. It is not the ultimate judge of its own truth. By this structure, the novel's practice of keeping watch over names replaces unilateral authority with collective reading.

Victory Through a Child's Hand: The Song's Sound of the Future

Chapter 99 opens with the folk song "Victory Through a Child's Hand," expressing the hope that a new generation's hands might loosen the grip between elephant and crocodile. The main event, however, is Satyavrat's admission of wrongdoing. Children provide the discipline of judgement, but no clear final victory over elephant or crocodile is shown. The song is therefore a future-facing sound of hope, not proof of an accomplished triumph in this chapter. The ending song returns to the enduring leaf of testimony and the response "Present." The song's promised success and the narrative's present incompleteness create literary tension.

The Shape of the Ending: Testimony Remains, but No Verdict

At the close, Satyavrat's testimony remains fixed as a page in the middle of the register. People say "Present," and a green point on the stump seems bright. The magical response gives a feeling of emotional fulfilment. Yet the phrase "silence, now seated under the punishment of listening" makes clear that punishment has begun, not ended. Neither restitution nor a definitive order of institutional reform is shown. Rather than declaring such incompleteness simply a fault or virtue, criticism may treat it as a considered opening for the next narrative strand.

Collective Action and Its Limits: Redistributing Heroism

Satyavrat's decision to speak is an important turning point. But without Ananya's insistence, Ba's gaze, Meera's principles of privacy, Devika's digital experience and the earlier testimony of workers' families, his admission would lack its context. The narrator locates a character's individual moral development within the process of collective memory. This is not a story in which a single great man delivers justice to everyone; it is an exercise in which a person of office writes down his own faults among people gaining the right to look. Critically, this is the chapter's central achievement. Its limit is that the reader has yet to see actual administrative reforms carried out.

Inter-Sectional Conclusion | Original Chapters 92–99

Beginning with the stump's unnatural shadow, these eight chapters proceed first through a warning from nature, then another flood, the crocodiles' encirclement and Lau's soaked document of negotiation. Thereafter, the inward responsibilities of four individuals emerge through different media: Batuknath's listening, Chandrapal's ledger, Raghav's leaf-message and Satyavrat's written testimony. The sequence of scenes does not detach inner transformation from the collective watch over names; it places it before the community that will test it.

The medium of testimony continues to change: name-stones, registers, copies preserved by memory, a raised platform above floodwater, account books, letters that cannot be erased, leaves and plain paper. Within the novel, each object confers a different relationship of authority. Children are not the automatic inheritors of authority; rather, their games, rules and questions prevent testimony from becoming the possession of a single party. A structure of heroism centred on one person is thus kept continually unstable.

Chronological inconsistencies also require scrutiny. The narrative does not clarify the transition between Batuknath's arrival on the flood night in Chapter 95 and his arrival on the third day of calm in Chapter 96. Variants in Chandrapal's childhood forms of address occur across Chapters 74, 81 and 97. Instead of correcting these differences without textual warrant, criticism must record them separately. The opening voices of the songs often anticipate themes of the following chapter: the account in Chapter 96, the signal in Chapter 97, and future victory in Chapter 99, while the moral outcome of the central events remains undecided.

Batuknath's night of listening is complete, but there has been no compensation for wrongdoing. Chandrapal considers carrying his accounts to the assembly, but no public financial disclosure has occurred. Raghav's sentence becomes a leaf, yet only the doorway to verified testimony has opened. Satyavrat's writing remains, but no order implementing institutional reform has been made. Such unfinishedness helps the reader apprehend the real duration of suffering more fully than an offender's tearful self-liberation would. The magical scenes give visible form to disputes over rights; they are not themselves their solutions.

Critical Section 201 | Original Chapter 100 — The Elephant, the Crocodile, and a Child's Hand

The Narrative Turn from Earlier Testimony to Collective Play

In Chapter 99, Satyavrat's written admission was placed among the pages of the register. Chapter 100 turns this solitary account of the self into a collective game. The setting remains the stump of the Channa tree, the circle of name-stones and the water left after the flood, but the primary unit of action changes. The question is no longer simply who confessed responsibility, but who has been seized and who possesses the authority to release them. Repetition of the subject thus creates a new arrangement rather than another recital of the same events. The fixed page of written testimony becomes connected to breathing bodies and the collective actions of children's hands.

Many Voices Claim the Meaning of the Elephant and Crocodile

Ba asks for the story of the elephant and the crocodile to be told again, but the elephant and crocodile are not supplied with fixed meanings in advance. Aruni identifies the trapped person with the elephant and the captor with the crocodile; Devika adds the act of listening to the meaning of the hand; Meera declares that an intervention carried out forcibly in the name of rescue may constitute another crocodile's grip. The polyphony is significant. Instead of imposing a prefabricated theory, the narrator allows a single metaphor to develop through the characters' different experiences. The familiar story rewrites the relationships among victim, listener, witness and would-be rescuer.

Ujjwal's Mother and the Digital Crocodile

Ujjwal's mother connects her son's digital entrapment to the elephant's predicament. Bank messages, threats, false claims of judicial authority and fear of public shame cease to be separate incidents; together they constitute the crocodile's tightening hold. She acknowledges that the call for help was initially mistaken for shame or foolishness. This self-criticism carries the family's focal perspective beyond a merely sentimental representation of grief. Devika connects the admission to the future task of educating children. By recounting past injury in a communal setting, the novel formulates a practical rule directed towards preventing its public recurrence.

The Workers' Deaths: A Metaphor Extending from Jaws to Language

In the bridge disaster the crocodile had signalled a real biological danger. Aruni, however, makes explicit that reducing workers' names to wage

figures, their bodies to accident statistics, and their deaths to contractual risk is another form of the crocodile's grip. This is an unusually concentrated figurative shift: the same violent action extends from a physical jaw to administrative language. Nevertheless, it would be mistaken to declare a living animal and an exploitative vocabulary entirely identical. The narrative makes the two levels resonate with each other; it does not establish them as literally the same thing.

Meera's Focal Perspective: The Rescuer's Hand Also Faces Questions

Meera reinterprets the elephant-and-crocodile story through the violation of privacy, social policing of love and the experience of blackmail. In her account, violence consists not only in the criminal's hand but also in the social gaze that repeatedly turns the injured person into an exhibit. Her objection to rescue undertaken without consent imposes a structural restraint on the chapter. Rather than declaring the child's hand unquestionably sacred, the narrative asks where its legitimate authority ends. This ethical uncertainty saves the scene from an easy division of the world into heroes and monsters.

Ananya's Spelling Error: A Small Act That Reveals a Larger Structure

When Ananya writes the word 'graah' (crocodile), she initially places a vowel mark incorrectly, laughs, crosses it out and corrects the word. Ba relates the moment to the obligation to acknowledge and correct mistakes rather than conceal them in the name of justice. The incident matters because its action is immediate and visible. A principle that has circulated through the speeches of several characters takes bodily form in a girl's pen, a misplaced mark and a revised word. Through this miniature event, the narrator anticipates the much larger struggle to write people's names correctly.

The Elephant Within the Wrongdoer: The Distance Between Compassion and Accountability

Through the old ghost's words, Batuknath, Chandrapal, Raghav and Lau are successively imagined as elephants trapped within themselves. Such humanisation does not amount to acquittal. Hariharan ceases to address Batuknath by his title and calls him 'Batuk'; Chandrapal moves from 'commission' towards the recognition of 'Chandrapal'; Raghav's breath catches; and Lau remains ensnared by the temptation of a nameless future. These scenes symbolically expose the wrongdoers' inward states. They do not establish that punishment, compensation or any concrete act of restitution has been completed.

Waiting Rather Than Grasping: The Child's Agency

Ananya reaches towards the crocodile's shadow, but instead of seizing it she waits, asking it first to speak a name. Later, when the response 'Present' is heard, the crocodile's teeth loosen. At this moment the imagined act of rescue changes from a forced victory into an act of listening. The girl is not presented as a miraculous figure who can solve every problem in the world. Her agency lies in altering the situation in which a question can be asked. Without the children's collective response, her individual voice would remain incomplete.

Physical Boundaries and the Foreshadowing of the Sky

The kabaddi line expands successively towards water, the stump, the name-stones and the sky. Lau's dream of a nameless planet offers a competing direction for that expansion: for him, leaving Earth promises release from history, whereas for the children crossing a boundary is inseparable from the pledge to return with a name. At dawn, two green leaves and a bent yellow star foreshadow the chapters of dreams to come. The scene is not evidence of an actual journey into space. It opens a horizon of shared imaginative possibility.

The Chapter-End Vigil of the Mongoose: A Figurative Appendix

After the principal elephant-and-crocodile narrative and its intervening song comes a prose passage entitled 'The Mongoose's Vigil'. In it, a mongoose that protects a child from a household snake becomes a guardian that remains constantly awake. This is not numbered Chapter 101; it is a special transitional text placed after Chapter 100. In contrast to the crocodile's predatory role, the mongoose's watch is described in a more two-sided manner. The positive, boundary-marking aspect attributed to the crocodile in an earlier chapter is thereby called into question anew. An editorial reading should not overlook this inconsistency.

Critical Section 202 | Original Chapter 101 — The Dream Invitation to a Nameless Planet

The Point of Entry into the Dream: A Shining Advertisement

Aruni sits by the stump among the register, a telephone and a half-open file. While looking at an advertisement for 'New Horizon Human Habitation', he falls asleep. The initial narrative level of the nameless planet is therefore explicit: it is a dream, not a verified space mission. The advertisement is an actual sign in the outer narrative; the planet it produces belongs to the dream state. The narrator places technological promotion alongside an inner fear at a common threshold, while still providing means to distinguish the different kinds of existence involved.

Dream Time: The Compression of Earlier Suffering into One Night

In Aruni's sleep, court dates, a mule account, drowned bodies and children's names intermingle. This dream time differs from the sequential time of ordinary events. Numerous social crises are compressed into a single chain of images. Through such condensation, the novel sets a long preceding narrative against the contrasting surface of a gleaming white planet. Because this chapter is short, it offers less material for a scene-by-scene examination; nevertheless, its concentrated imagery constructs a significant miniature narrative.

The Frightening Design of a Society Without Sorrow

On the planet there are no rivers, cremation grounds or roots; numbers replace names and satisfied smiles replace the memory of loss. What appears at first to be a utopia acquires the opposite meaning: the price of having no sorrow is the erasure of any account of its causes. When memory disappears, the wrongdoer is also released from the demand for an accounting. The planet's apparently innocent order therefore resembles institutionalised forgetting. The scene is a thought experiment within the narrative, not a scientific assertion about the environment of an actual planet.

Ba Is Absent in Body but Present in Voice

Within the dream Ba does not appear bodily. Only her questioning voice is heard. This narrative device changes the mode of her presence: a character who is no longer directly visible gains authority on the inward stage of Aruni's memory. Ananya immediately asks whether everyone has become equal or everyone has been made nameless together. Her question exposes the implausibility of the planet's displayed smiles. Voices belonging to remembered characters interrupt the internal logic of the dream.

Meera and the Disappearance of Consent

Seeing the words 'cultural memory sample' written on a wall, Meera tightens her red thread. Her declaration, 'I am not a sample', renews her objection to the appropriation of her story even within the dream. The thread condenses the earlier history of the women's assembly and the requirement of permission before images are used. To question the nameless planet's assurances, the novel employs neither a wonder of space science nor a technical explanation, but the repeated experience of privacy and consent in ordinary social life.

The Industrialist's Signature and the Erasure of His Own Name

Lau's glass chamber and immaculate accounts constitute a supposedly safe space for the market in the dream. Yet, when he tries to sign, the letters of his own name disappear. Chandrapal's percentages, Batuknath's title and Raghav's signal remain, while the person vanishes. This symbolic reversal defeats the claim to financial control from within its own logic. The loss even reaches the characters' private memories. Nevertheless, what occurs is a dream image, not documentary evidence that real bank accounts or passports have been erased.

Ananya's Hand and the Condition for Crossing

Aruni wants to rise, but a kabaddi line shines beneath his feet. Taking his hand, Ananya says that they may cross the line, but must bring back one name. This act establishes the governing rule of the game in the chapter that follows. Rather than inviting escape, the dream becomes a test. Its conclusion announces no final decision; instead, it sets out a method of resistance to the temptation of flight.

The Earlier Nameless and the Repeated Image of Space Ahead

The word 'nameless' in the title connects people whose names have disappeared through violence to a civilisation beyond Earth that has no names. The similarity, however, conceals an essential difference: the first absence is the consequence of an injury, while the second is promoted as the goal of an advertisement. By holding these meanings apart, the narrative exposes a wish to abolish accountability hidden within the language of a beautiful future. The slow dream-kabaddi sequence of the next chapter will turn that proposition into a procedure of testing.

Critical Section 203 | Original Chapter 102 — Kabaddi Among Planets in a Dream

Bodies Remain Still While Consciousness Travels

At the beginning of the chapter the narrator makes clear that the children's bodies are seated on Earth beside the Channa stump; only their shadows reach the planet in the dream. The sentence establishes a boundary between physical space travel and a journey undertaken in sleep. Reading the novel's expansion into the heavens as an actual spacecraft flight would redirect the interpretation away from what the text states. The dream becomes a laboratory in which the familiar rules of kabaddi can be tested under different social conditions.

The Breath of the Game: Measuring Tension

Ananya requires every player who crosses a line to find a forgotten name and bring it back. The first task is not to increase speed but to steady the breath. In ordinary kabaddi, entering the opposing side and returning safely form the centre of the action. Here the event's outcome is defined by the return with someone's lost name. The physical rhythm of the game measures the narrative time of the ethical responsibility involved in reading out names.

A Visible Scene of a Girl's Fear

Ananya's knees tremble and her throat dries. She does not put on the mask of a fearless heroic figure. Remembering her mother's instruction, 'If you are afraid, speak a name', she says 'Ujjwal'. The difference between unbidden fear and deliberately chosen action makes her character credible. The chapter does not propose that magical power will abolish fear. It shows that pronouncing a remembered name can create the courage required to take a step.

Nameless Guards and a Society of Numbers

The guardians of the domes have numbers on their chests instead of faces. They advise the visitors to abandon names because names, they claim, are the source of sorrow. Meera offers the opposing argument: suffering does not arise from names, but from violence committed against those who bear them. This is a dramatic collision of articulated ideas, yet the novel does not leave it at the level of speeches. Meera's image appears on the wall and fades after she refuses to be displayed. The scene itself enacts the consequence of the argument.

Satyavrat's Line: From Official Titles to Confession

Satyavrat first pronounces the words 'officer', 'witness' and 'law', but the boundary does not open. When he speaks of his admission, made too late, the line moves. The magical rule is not simply a criticism of legal titles; it is also a rereading of the testimony already written within the narrative. The statement fixed on paper in Chapter 99 becomes the means of crossing a dream-boundary with the body. In this way the story establishes recurrence across written text and embodied performance.

Aruni's Odourless Earth

The dust of the dream planet has no scent and is extraordinarily clean. Against this surface, Aruni remembers the bridge foundations, a worker's gamchha and messages that have been erased. The absence of smell is a decisive image: the earth's very earthiness arises from a history of relationships. To mistake technological cleanliness for absolute moral purity would be a serious critical error. Beneath the spotless surface is not unforgotten pain but a structure deprived of the signs through which suffering might be remembered.

The Game Slows and the Narrative Grows Denser

The text explicitly says that the game does not become faster. Every step brings a question; every touch brings a name. This slowing of narrative time does not fill the scene with fruitless delay. Rather, it creates a sequence of minute decisions. At the final whispered word 'Present', a crack opens in the wall. By avoiding a triumphant announcement of victory, this moment acknowledges the narrative force of a voice reduced almost to its minimum.

The Smell of Water and the Recitation of Names to Come

Through the crack enters the smell of Earth's water. The biological memory of a river absent from the planet now enters the dream. In this inward landscape the environment is not a passive background but a disruption of the system of forgetting. Instead of announcing that the game has ended, the text states that the recitation of names is beginning. The dream's achievement is therefore not a final conquest, but the opening of a door towards a new collective act of narration.

Critical Section 204 | Original Chapter 103 — Reciting Names on the Nameless Planet of the Dream

The Lifeless Hall of Numbers

The figures 30, 300, 791 and 0 appear on the wall, forming a series of numbers in place of the stories of people. When Ananya opens the register, relationships emerge with each name: a mother's lamp, a child learning to steer a boat, and an unpaid wage slip still held by a wife. In this arrangement, names do not simply cancel numbers. They reveal again the layers of experience concealed behind them. The narrator's skill consists less in a general denunciation of numbers than in creating scenes of relationships.

The Contrast Between a Short Song and Long Experience

The dream song is very brief, yet it promises that each name will awaken the scent of earth and the sound of a closed door. The main scene gradually unfolds that promise. There is a stylistic change between the song's brevity and the longer folk songs of preceding chapters. It would be improper to eliminate the difference by assuming a single metrical convention throughout. In the dream sequence, the song functions as a key that opens the scene.

Meera's Writing of Memory with Permission

Meera reads the names of those whose private images have been turned into threats, adding an explicit condition of consent to each one. Consequently the hall grows less dazzling, and the air becomes easier to breathe. This symbolic alteration makes the breakdown of technological control over display visible within the story. Recovering a name never amounts to unrestricted permission to make the entirety of a person's life public. The novel establishes this difficult distinction through its central action, rather than attaching it as an external moral lesson.

Batuknath's Self-Defence and the Return of the Dream Court

Batuknath again hears his grandchild's question: did he preserve justice, or merely his profession? His answer drawn from the science of lineage falls apart as worms from a file. This magical image destroys the formal language of self-defence, but it does not replace that defence with immediate forgiveness from those harmed. Fear of losing prestige may become an inner root of wrongdoing. That is a narrative interpretation of the character's experience, not a reason to absolve him of guilt.

Chandrapal's Wound Around His Own Name and Its Contradiction

Chandrapal remembers that his name was once read incorrectly at school. Yet this earlier humiliation did not prevent him from turning innumerable other people's names into percentages. Self-pity here offers no ethical release; it exposes hypocrisy. The novel's technique is forceful: the fact that someone suffered in the past does not automatically justify their later exploitation of others. A single moment of memory breaks apart the character's attempt to construct a simple, exculpatory autobiography.

The Return of the Voices Raghav Erased

Every message Raghav deletes reappears on the wall: a woman's unfinished sentence, a worker's appeal for help and a child's fear. Even when he covers his ears, he hears the voices within. The significance of their return is not confined to the marvellous. The dream rejects the claim that communication technology can make a record cease to matter simply by declaring it destroyed. The scene attacks the false equation that the destruction of an archive also means the termination of responsibility.

A Water Stain on Lau's Immaculate Account Book

Lau calls names an obstacle to the market. Ananya replies that names are a means of demanding an accounting. After this brief exchange, a stain of water spreads across his ledger. 'Name' and 'account' shift from the narrow register of financial calculation towards the social and juridical accounting owed to injured people. But the scene takes place within a dream. It supplies no independent evidence that the accounts of any actual company have been altered.

A Blank Page for the Name Not Yet Found

Aruni writes, 'For the one whose name has not yet been found', and the largest number breaks apart. The action matters because the right to a name is not restricted to those whose deaths have already been documented. Leaving space for the unidentified is an acknowledgement that further investigation and listening remain necessary. At the dream's end the planet is not destroyed; its shine fades and ordinary earth is revealed. The return of memory does not end the world, but makes it possible to begin living its difficult life.

Critical Section 205 | Original Chapter 104 — Awakening: Garh Narikel Chooses Earth

Focalisation at the Passage from Dream to Waking

Aruni wakes at dawn. The extinguished telephone, the open register and the bark of the stump make the actual surroundings concrete again. Ananya, Meera, Satyavrat and the children are present. Yet no one establishes with certainty whether they all had the same dream or produced a similar story out of a shared fear. This indeterminacy is significant. The novel accepts the collective character of social imagination without supplying unqualified verification of a single supernatural occurrence.

The 'Real' Form of the Blue Dust

On the unnamed planet of the dream there was pale blue-white dust. After waking, the colour on Ananya's palm is ordinary chalk from the school. This substitution offers a possible worldly explanation for the preceding marvel. The narrator makes no unnecessary claim that dust was physically carried back from another planet. Ananya herself says, 'We did not go anywhere', leaving the truth-status of the magical narrative open rather than finally settling it.

Ba's Sentence: Feet Must Be Placed on Earth

Ba says that the body need not travel for a journey of the mind, but after waking one must place one's feet on the earth. This succinct statement forms a bridge between the experiment of dreaming and social action. It can be read as the chapter's central practical instruction, because Meera makes renewed decisions about consent, Satyavrat about identification in writing, and Aruni about the actual source of the advertisement after Ba speaks.

Exposing 'New Horizon': The Search for an External Crime

Aruni checks the source and discovers that 'New Horizon' is not a real planetary settlement programme. It is a promotional test for a criminal network collecting data about fear, escape and the desire to forget. Broom's ethical language, Lau's money, Chandrapal's registrations and Raghav's messaging connections are implicated. This disclosure is a significant advance in the novel's verifiable plot. The earlier celestial images acquire a new connection to a network of social manipulation, rather than proving that the dream's planet existed.

Meera Reties Her Red Thread

Meera unties and ties her red thread again. As external action it is small, yet it renews the recurring sign of the women's night assembly and their rule of consent. The dream has not erased her earlier injury. She reasserts the boundaries of ownership over her own story. The strength of this literary image lies in its refusal of the artificially comforting solution that the wound has somehow dissolved.

Satyavrat's Name Rather Than His Office

In his note Satyavrat rejects forgetting as an alternative to rehabilitation. He strikes out the designation 'officer' and writes his own name. The testimony recorded in Chapter 99 and the condition for crossing a line in the dream of Chapter 102 are thus made tangible in everyday paperwork. The plot tests the same human change at three levels: oral, dreamlike and written. This recurrence strengthens the credibility of a change in the character, but does not in itself establish that administrative reform has occurred.

The Children's Choice of Earth

The children write that they will not erase sorrow but change its causes; leaving Earth cannot make an offence innocent. Their sentence is declarative, yet it specifies the direction of the next tasks: rewriting names that have been struck out, listening for consent concerning bodies, and opening the accounts of labour. The choice in this chapter is therefore more than an emotional attachment to home. It is a working extension of the rules of remembrance the children have themselves constructed.

Unfinished Labour for Those Responsible

For Batuknath, Chandrapal and Raghav, choosing Earth does not amount to receiving a certificate of forgiveness. The narrative enumerates the tasks still before them—the recovery of files, accounts and voices—without showing their full execution. The distinction between acknowledging responsibility and completing social restitution is preserved. For a critic, this incompleteness is a feature of the novel's narrative time, not an error to be dismissed through an instantaneous resolution.

The Dawn Shoot: Limits of Treating Nature as an Outcome

At the end, dew rests on a new shoot and Ananya writes down her reasons for choosing Earth. The shoot is not merely ornamental hope; it is the living remainder of a felled tree. Nevertheless, the emergence of green leaves does not mean that floods, contracts and digital crimes have ceased to be problems. The image signifies the possibility of a future. The struggle

over seeds and soil in the next chapter will bring that possibility before the test of social work.

Critical Section 206 | Original Chapter 105 — Earth's First Vigil

The Opening Touch: The Roughness of the Tree and the Dust of Dreams

Ananya touches the wet bark of the Channa stump. Blue dust from the dream is said to remain on her palm, only to be absorbed by the soil. This narrative detail creates a tension with Chapter 104's ordinary explanation in terms of chalk. There, the girl had said that they had gone nowhere; here, the dust reappears as a visible residue of remembered dreaming. It would be inappropriate to treat this as incontrovertible evidence of actual space travel. The image of memory and the tactile sensation of mud occupy concurrent levels of the narrative.

Ujjwal's Light and Devika's Silence

On the surface of the water, Ujjwal's spirit seems to tremble in the form of a light; Devika does not wish to call him by name. Her decision refuses the repeated exhibition of grief. The implication that certain presences, if called upon, may be bound once more to sorrow introduces a necessary qualification to the previously established communal rule that every name must be read aloud. The right to a name must also leave room for choosing not to speak. This tension is disclosed through the character's action rather than a general pronouncement.

The Newspaper and Folk Memory: Two Centres of Perception

The city newspaper calls the dream-kabaddi an instance of rural superstition, while the village interprets its experience differently. The novel does not proclaim the two positions equally reliable. Rather, it distinguishes the categorical judgement of external news reporting from the qualified uncertainty of local experience. Supernatural images remain vividly present within the fictional world; in critical analysis, however, they must not be converted into verified journalistic facts.

Redistributing Work to Former Wrongdoers

Batuknath is told to recover names from suppressed files, Chandrapal to return the names he appropriated, and Raghav to seek the voices of those he had rendered invisible. These instructions invert the characters' relations of power. Those who once exercised control must now work under the scrutiny of communal readers. The passage from repentance to labour matters, but no scene establishes that the people who suffered have granted any of them complete forgiveness.

The Uncertainty of Lau's Whereabouts

The chapter explicitly leaves unsettled whether Lau has returned abroad or remains in a hotel in India. This matters because earlier episodes involving his flight, hotel, arrival in the village and appearance in a distant glass building did not form an entirely consistent sequence. Such uncertainty might acknowledge the narrator's conscious limitations; it might equally reflect editorial looseness in the chronology and geography. A responsible reading must register it as an open question of narrative time and place.

New Rules of Kabaddi Around the Sprout

The circle first enclosed the dead person's name, then the wrongdoer's hearing, then the planet of the dream; now it marks the boundary of kabaddi around a new shoot. Ananya assigns successive breaths to earth, water, names and the nameless. A child whose breath fails is not expelled from the game but seated among those who listen. Punishment within play becomes a relationship oriented towards correction. Such revisions to the rules make the imagined children's school more credible.

The Living Crocodile and the Double Presence of the Metaphor

A crocodile's eyes shine in the water, yet the characters no longer regard it solely as a violent adversary. Ba suggests a different meaning of hunger, while the children continue guarding the names. The living aquatic animal and the symbolic 'crocodile' occupy the same text. We should not mistake the human meanings attributed by the narrative to an actual creature for facts of natural history. The animal world's limits and the institutions of human wrongdoing retain distinct identities.

Distinct Voices of the Stones: Collective Agreement

The name-stones ring together, yet each has a different sound. Rather than compare the noise with a judge's gavel or a temple bell, the narrator describes it as agreement rising from the earth. The enchanted music of this scene preserves the tension between collective assent and the separate memories of individuals. The encounter of multiple sounds, not the repetition of a single slogan, shapes the vocal composition of the narrative community.

The Unresolved Doubt at the End of the First Vigil

Satyavrat sits behind the children. His posture may be read less as an abandonment of rank than as the bodily enactment of learning to listen. Amid the sprout, dew and reading of names, the narrative sings of rebirth, but the final vigil has only begun. To call the Earth 'newborn' is not to announce a sentimental solution: the care of a newborn demands continuing labour.

Critical Section 207 | Original Chapter 106 — The Vigil over Seeds

From Names to Seeds: The Expansion of the Action

Ba asks the children to guard seeds after guarding names. The arrival of this new concern is not abrupt. The preceding chapter's fresh sprout and first vigil over the Earth, together with the forgetting imagined on the nameless planet, prepared the question of living sources for the future. At first the children laugh, taking seeds for tiny household objects. Ba's question—if the seeds do not survive, whence will the words in the mouths of future generations come?—gives that laughter a grave significance.

A Dense Catalogue of Containers and Natural Things

At the coconut-leaf school, the children place rice, sesame, madua (finger millet), kodo and kutki millets, makhana, sugarcane, mango stones, jackfruit seeds, neem, peepal and the green tip of Channa. The list does not merely inventory botanical diversity. Each seed prompts questions about season, field, hunger, song and custodianship. This accumulating specificity sets the plurality of lived local worlds against the administrative singularity of 'protection'.

Women's Memories in Domestic Vessels

Women bring seeds in brass bowls, earthen pots, tins and old bundles. The narrator differentiates the sounds and smells of these containers, making the material world a bearer of memory. Seeds associated with a daughter's departure, seeds saved after famine and varieties that sprouted after flooding cannot easily be absorbed into a single category of 'samples'. Women's domestic knowledge is not presented merely as an objection to scientific conservation; it constitutes another language of the archive within the novel.

Meera's 'Privacy of Seeds': Scope and Limits

Meera argues that the women themselves have the right to tell their seeds' stories: some may be made public; others remain within a closed circle. This extends earlier rules of consent concerning bodies, photographs and love. A seed, however, is not a human agent capable of giving consent. 'The privacy of seeds' is a literary metaphor for people's control over knowledge and traditions associated with them. Regard for living nature and the limits of communal decision-making appear together in this formulation.

The Government Jeep: The Double Language of Conservation

A jeep marked 'Advanced Seed Collection and Climate Security Project' arrives with officials and consultants. Beneath their courtesy lies the contradiction posed by the 'commercial potential' recorded on a tablet. The villagers first hear the outside proposal and only then question it. This restraint is an achievement of the writing. Instead of casting all science as an automatic villain, the text critiques a particular contract, the reduction of names to numbers and the possibility of appropriation.

'Sing the Song': A Scene Testing the Right to Authority

Ba asks the official about the seed's song, the quantity of water it needs, its sowing season and its forgotten local names. He remains silent. The episode is more than a joke at an expert's expense: it stages the unequal encounter of two languages of knowledge. His inability to answer exposes the project's limited local understanding, but it does not demonstrate that every scientific seed collection is pointless. The narrative gives human shape and rhythm to the insufficiency of this particular proposal.

Digital Records: Conservation or Appropriation?

On the tablet, Gop Kumar finds codes, geolocations, family and caste details, yields, tolerance characteristics and commercial potential. Gathering information is not intrinsically criminal; ownership, purpose and use are the issues. The device recalls the earlier memorial application, but the object of control has shifted from the names of the dead to the future of living seeds. A repeated narrative procedure thus reveals the operation of a market mechanism under changed circumstances.

The Return of Dream-Dust

After the jeep leaves, a fine white trace is found on the shoot and associated with the dust of the dream. This is an ambiguous continuity of magical realism, not a certificate proving a digital conspiracy. Ananya raises the possibility that 'New Horizon' wants seed data. In the following chapter, the contract's fine print will give that suspicion a more concrete basis in the action of the plot.

The Voice of Seeds and a New Heading

At night, words seem to come from inside the vessels: not a serial number, but soil; not a vault, but a season. The personified seeds lead the narrative towards the coming question of 'the theft of seeds'. Ananya opens a fresh page and writes its heading. The chapter ends not by resolving the danger but by recognising it, thereby providing a narrative bridge to the next chapter.

Critical Section 208 | Original Chapter 107 — The Theft of Seeds

A New Definition of Possible Theft

The opening distinguishes two forms of theft: one is committed secretly at night, the other in daylight through documents and in the name of 'security'. This distinction shifts the narrative away from the familiar suspense of a clandestine crime and towards the prolonged process of transferring rights. Seeds may remain in the field even while control over their names, uses and future is taken elsewhere. That possibility is the chapter's central conflict.

Surmani Kaki's 'Submerged Breath'

Surmani Kaki keeps a flood-tolerant rice variety called 'Submerged Breath' in a small brass tin. According to her mother's account, the variety can withstand three days under water. The novel presents this as a character's inherited family memory, not as a trait scientifically certified by a laboratory. The name gathers together flooding, breathing and ancestral narrative. Her touch, the coolness of the container and the transmission of memory give the grain an identity at once material and narrative.

The Research Team's Fine Print

The official paper bears a heading concerning the 'Conservation of Indigenous Seeds and the Study of Interplanetary Adaptation'. The smaller print mentions their possible use in an off-world habitation project. This scene establishes a concrete connection between Chapter 104's promotional experiment for 'New Horizon' and the seed-collection agreement. The contract clause is an actual document within the plot; the dream journey to the nameless planet was not an actual journey. To collapse the two into a single kind of event would be a misreading.

Linguistic Priority: Ira's Intervention

A foreign woman researcher begins to ask questions, but Ira insists that the owner of the field and its seeds must first be answered in her own Maithili language. This is not a demand to prohibit translation; it transfers the centre of the conversation. Previously, the external project's vocabulary established the framework for decisions. Now the local cultivator's language subjects that framework to questioning. Through the character's intervention, geographical distance is translated into a contest over linguistic authority.

'Anonymisation' and the Severing of Memory from Context

Meera finds the word 'anonymisation' in the seed agreement. She observes that if the field, season, family, women's labour and memory of floods are removed, seeds can become 'nameless goods'. This is not a comprehensive technical discussion of the legitimate uses of privacy protection in digital systems. The target of criticism is the particular proposal to erase local identities while securing commercial control. The narrative discloses the asymmetry between numbering objects and severing the relationships that give them meaning.

A Scientific Answer and an Official Threat

The official defends the need for serial numbers; Ananya asks about the seeds' germination, scent and seasons. When he cannot answer, he raises the possibility of 'legal acquisition'. This is the decisive turn in the dialogue. A proposal expressed in the polite language of conservation moves towards the possibility of coercive appropriation backed by authority. At this moment, the project's actual power relations become intelligible to the reader.

Ba's Satire and the Boundary of Women's Bodies

Ba recounts the sequence of appropriations—from land and water to names and seeds—and asks whether the next claim might be laid upon the womb itself. The exaggeration is a rhetorical warning within the novel; no actual state appropriation of a pregnancy occurs in the chapter. The thunderous collective response of the women expands the issue from seed ownership to the means by which future generations will live.

The Circle of Play as a Boundary of Rights

At Devika's signal, the children do not seize the vessels and flee. They place them in the middle and form a circle around them. The official's shoe comes to a halt at that line. Though brief, this physical obstruction is a powerful scene. Kabaddi previously defended names; now a communal boundary marks the question of who may decide the biological future of fields. The victory is symbolic. The final legal outcome concerning acquisition remains undetermined.

Dissent Within the Team: The Foreign Researcher's Decision

The woman researcher may not have been told all the project's conditions. Instead of taking a 'sample', she chooses to sit and listen. This change prevents the narrative from giving all outside researchers the same grasping face. Differences of information and the possibility of ethical choice exist within the visiting team. Her position is conveyed through her own action, not merely through the narrator's general moral instruction.

The Communal Rule of 'Seeds' Testimony'

By evening, the children establish a rule suspending outside collection unless the seed's name, home, field, season and story have been clearly established. Protection of language and communal rights thus becomes part of caring for seeds. The rule does not categorically prohibit research; it specifies conditions governing its procedure and ownership. Following a temporary halt, the narrative leaves open the difficult institutional questions of how these conditions will operate.

The Soil Speaks: An Unanswered Question After Victory

At midnight, a question rises from the earthen vessel: 'Where shall I grow?' Through personification, the narrator refuses to stop at the immediate victory of having 'prevented the theft of seeds'. Fields are caught amid debt, chemical use, floods, drought and caste divisions. Where is there a place for the protected seed to live? This is the new crisis. The final title, 'The Mouth of the Soil', opens the way to the next chapter, accepting a deeper problem instead of declaring total victory.

Inter-Sectional Discussion: Chapters 100–107

After Satyavrat's personal testimony, Chapter 100 reopens the story of the elephant and the crocodile. This is not a mere repetition of information: the experiences of Ujjwal's mother, Aruni, Meera and Devika give a single metaphor multiple meanings. The child's hand becomes not an external miracle of deliverance but an agency of listening and restoring names. The supplementary transitional text titled 'Bijji's Vigil' further complicates that significance.

The pace of Chapters 101–104 differs from that of other parts of the book. Brief dream episodes, short dream songs, numbered domes and the exchange of a name for a crack combine into a compressed imaginative narrative. Watching the promotional advertisement in the frame narrative, and examining its source upon waking, are actual events within that frame; the glass domes of the nameless planet belong to a dream-bound thought experiment. Erasing this difference in narrative levels would destroy a distinction established by the novel itself.

The reading of names in this sequence is more than a list of the dead. Aruni's empty page, Meera's insistence on consent, Raghav's rewritten message, Batuknath's files and Chandrapal's percentages are competing forms of a social archive. Forgetting is advertised as an opportunity for personal rest, yet it carries the danger of losing the account of crimes committed against particular people.

In Chapters 105–107, the sprout, dew, crocodile, rice, seed vessels and brass tin move into the centre of the story. The future is redirected from an imagined departure from Earth towards the question of land in which something can grow on Earth. The family memory attached to 'Submerged Breath', the small-print conditions of a government proposal, the anonymisation of seeds and the children's circular vigil reveal concrete procedures of social control.

Changes in the positioning of songs also require examination. Chapter 100 contains an extended children's kabaddi folk song; Chapters 101–104 have shorter dream and awakening songs; Chapter 105 introduces an earthly birth song, while Chapters 106–107 draw upon the idiom of seeds. These are differing temporal rhythms within the same work. It would be inadequate to dismiss them all as ornament; it would be equally uncritical to claim that every song corresponds perfectly to the events of its chapter.

The final achievement of these eight chapters is not the elimination of their problems. Chapter 104 exposes the promotional experiment associated with 'New Horizon', and Chapter 107 establishes a temporary communal rule concerning external seed collection. Questions of farmland, acquisition, debt, floods, chemical use and caste inequality nevertheless remain. The forthcoming title 'The Mouth of the Soil' indicates that securing the future involves more than keeping seeds in a container: it requires making available the social ground in which they may grow.

Textual Basis

Gajendra Thakur, Gohi Sabhak Beech Jalsamadhi, original Maithili trilogy, Chapters 100–107. Philosophical episodes appearing in the novel are treated here as narrative material; the testing of evidence according to Navya-Nyaya is not the method employed in this criticism.

Critical Section 209 | Original Chapter 108 — The Mouth of the Soil

The New Vigil Begins by Reversing the Question

The central action of Chapter 108 arises not from the triumph of preventing the theft of seeds, but from the uncomfortable question that triumph has produced: where, finally, will the rescued seeds grow? This structural reversal turns the preceding chapter's ending directly into the next chapter's crisis. The author does not rest content with protection as an achievement; he reveals the distance between conservation and the conditions that make life possible. The earthen vessels near the Channa stump themselves seem to pose the question, but its answer lies in the organisation of fields, labour and rights. Inanimate soil speaking is a magical-realist procedure with an emphatically concrete social centre.

Opening Folk Idiom and Collective Action

The opening prose exposes the illusion that ploughing, selling, dividing or mortgaging land amounts to 'talking with the soil'. The narrator then turns that proposition into action through Ananya's register, Surmani Kaki's palm and Ira's questioning. Idea, scene and testing follow one another in three stages, preventing the chapter from becoming a mere sermon. Its primary narrative force lies in the way an unanswered question prompts the children to undertake the concrete work of reading the names of fields.

Reading the Names of Fields: An Archive of a New Geography

Bargadahi, the edge of the Musahari settlement, Ujjar Dih, the low-lying land beyond the Kamla, Belahi's fallow plot and sharecropped fields are all named. This topographical enumeration is not decoration but an archival narrative device. The landowner's name, the sharecropper's labour, debt, litigation and the date of flooding are separate layers within a single field. Earlier, names were read to remember the dead; now the land itself demands protection against namelessness. The act of naming extends from persons to places without effacing the different relationships attached to each plot.

Conflict Through the Offer of a 'Pure' Field

Harihar Jha offers a 'pure' field on higher ground, taking pride in the claim that its soil has not been touched by the labour of the Chamar and Dusadh settlements. The violence here is not physical; it inheres in the language of selection. Meera questions the proposal, Surmani Kaki counters the caste division by invoking the seed's hunger, and Ananya asks

what could make soil itself the source of purity. Rather than offer a ready-made ideological speech, the narrative uncovers the system of values concealed within a proposed choice. Selecting a field suddenly supplies the social scene with a conflict.

Dhiramati Enters: A Shift in Focalisation

Dhiramati, granddaughter of Jagesar Mochi, steps forward holding a clod of earth. Her entrance means more than the admission of an excluded hamlet into the narrative. She demands a voice in choosing the land. She offers for the experiment her own fallow plot, flooded in the rains and cracked in the heat. The narration brings her roughened palm, its marks of labour and the neglected land into a single visual grouping. In this focalisation, a marginalised character ceases to be an object of pity and becomes an active source of decision.

Choosing Five Soils: A Polycentric Structure

Instead of choosing a single 'best' field, the community selects five contrasting sites: fallow land in the Chamar settlement, the flood-washed lowland of the Musahari, a widow's garden, a labourer's sharecropped field and a communal bed beside the stump. They are given five names: sorrow, water, endurance, labour and memory. Replacing a single centre with several is an important compositional choice. Geography becomes a comparative testing ground for social claims, although the narrative has not yet demonstrated what the future harvests will yield.

Matter's Journey from Palm to Seedbed

Surmani Kaki places the first grain in Dhiramati's hand. The smooth seed and the rough palm are described together; material contact does more work here than an abstract declaration of equality. While the fallow ground is cleared, a fragment of an old shoe is kept as a memorial. Dung, ash, flood silt and dust from the stump are mixed into the soil. The insistence that clearing ground must not entail erasing its history joins the novel's practice of archiving to agricultural labour.

The Transformation of the Procession

In contrast to the commercial procession of counterfeit ghosts, this is a silent journey of children, seed vessels, women, labourers and elders. The narrator reuses an earlier performative device—the procession—with a changed purpose. This time those who watch do not remain spectators: they join along the route and participate in the working community's action. The declaration that they are going to 'hear the mouth of the soil' prevents the episode from swelling into a pilgrimage or festival and turns it instead into a test of listening.

The Crocodile and the Temporary Peace at a New Boundary

As the first seeds are planted, a crocodile's black back appears in the Kamla-Balan water. The text makes the precise distinction that it watched, but did not eat. This small action interrupts an older relationship of fear without claiming that the animal's nature has permanently changed. The sparing use of magical suggestion works effectively here: the creature's attention heightens the public importance of the activity without guaranteeing its outcome.

Narrative Time: From Vigil to the Agricultural Season

The vigil over names largely involved immediate remembrance and a presence renewed night after night. With the sowing of seeds, time becomes a matter of seasons, water, germination, fertility and repeated labour. The story connects the time of mourning with the slower time of cultivation. Planting can be accomplished in a day, but the questions of land tenure, sharecropping, caste barriers and viable yields extend through the year. The chapter's optimism is therefore not a complete resolution but the beginning of collective responsibility.

The Limits of Authorial Claims Within Dialogue

References to Gangesha and the scriptures appear as part of the characters' language and questions. The critic must not substitute these exchanges for independently verified historical statements. In narrative terms, their function is to challenge claims of caste purity in the fields. Similarly, 'a seed does not ask one's caste' is an ethical intervention by a character, not a report of a scientific experiment. Keeping these levels distinct makes the novel's critical force clearer.

Unresolved Questions and the Next Chapter on Water

Five kinds of soil have been chosen and the seeds planted. Yet questions about enduring rights to the land, the distribution of the harvest and assured protection for neglected settlements remain unanswered. It is precisely this incompleteness that gives the chapter its strength. The movement from the voice of soil to the memory of water does more than change the natural element under consideration: it shifts attention from named, relatively fixed plots to water's moving routes. The open ending generates the narrative necessity of the next chapter.

Critical Section 210 | Original Chapter 109 — Water's Memory

From Ground to Flow: A Change in Focalisation

From the planted seeds and named fields of 'The Mouth of the Soil', the next chapter moves towards the flowing memory of water. Its opening wonder is the sight, at daybreak, of names apparently floating in small pools around the stump. The central narrative question is not whether water can literally speak a supernatural truth, but how relationships beyond the reach of a fixed register may be made audible. Stone holds a name; water holds its passage. This distinction between object and movement organises the chapter as a whole.

The Wet Register and an Inverted Outcome

In ordinary experience, water blurs ink. Here the register is soaked, but its letters do not run; circles of water form around unfinished names. This deliberate reversal is a subtle centre of magical realism. Water changes from the adversary of a fragile archive into the companion of an incomplete one. The scene offers an inverse image of the pressure of social erasure: the very substance that might destroy written records brings new outlines to suppressed names.

The Arrival of Panidubbi and Narrative Authority

Panidubbi sits on the bank, half water and half shadow. Her speech goes beyond the simple personification of a river because she instructs the community to make a map. The distinction between 'name' and 'movement' clarifies her role. The narrator does not turn this mythic figure into an authority delivering a final judgement; she inspires a different practice of recording. Consequently, the active labour of Ananya, Gop, Ira and the women is not displaced from the story.

The Official Map and the Living Waterways

On Gop Kumar's official sheet, the river is a straight line, the bridge a black stroke and the settlement a coloured circle. Panidubbi objects to that simplification: the image is not water, only colour. On the children's new map, waves mark the places of missing workers' names, a dry well marks the absence of a hospital, and a water-filled screen stands for digital fraud. Cartography changes from a means of measuring distance into a way of reading the routes of social harm.

A Map of Smells: Sensory Focalisation

Ira's question about children living away from home inspires the idea of a 'map of smells'. People bring different samples of water from homes, wells, paddy fields, hospital taps and river landings. The odours of iron, algae, wet straw and medical premises shift the focal point from sight to smell and recollection. The reader does not merely see the geography, but experiences it through layered scents. Such an experiment prevents the novel's ecological narrative from depending exclusively on visual description.

Satyavrat Washes His Hands

Panidubbi asks Satyavrat to wash his hands instead of writing. In the water, letters resembling 'silence', 'delay', 'witness' and 'debt' rise on his fingers. A man previously associated with the authority of documents finds his body briefly transformed into an archive. The touch does not pronounce a final verdict on guilt; it creates a fresh experience of self-acknowledgement. After a written statement, corporeal remembering becomes necessary, and the narrative gives weight to this other medium.

Waterways of Weeping

The image of Ujjwal's light and his mother's tears joins a death linked with the digital world to the river's geography. Grief that had seemed an event confined to a screen enters the memory of water through the mother's tears. The differences between media do not disappear: a screen's circulation, a body's pain and water's remembering remain separate levels. The emotional journey of a name crosses spatial boundaries without dissolving an individual's particular suffering into an abstraction.

The Feet of a Neglected Caste and Waterborne Testimony

An elderly leatherworker comes forward to speak of the absence of his ancestors' names. His wife's request that his feet be washed with water symbolically restores dignity to labour long subjected to humiliation. In place of the government trust's term 'harmony', actions—lifting a water pot, pouring water, making room for a name—become narrative evidence. It would be insufficient to see this scene merely as a ceremonial proclamation against social hierarchy. It is a social action that alters where those feet may stand.

Expanding the Circle and Rewriting Kabaddi

At dusk the pools join one another and form a circle around the stump. The children play kabaddi on its edge, but lifting a name no longer means lifting a stone: it means bearing the weight of a name in one's chest. The rules of the game are not repeated in a fixed form; they change with the

subject. In keeping with water's fluidity, kabaddi becomes a means of carrying moving memory and the rhythm of breath.

The Arrival of Bottled 'Sacred Memory Water'

At the chapter's end, a market vehicle arrives proposing to bottle and sell reverence. Even as the narrative constructs a material archive, it immediately exposes the danger of commodifying it. The communal memory carried along waterways, belonging to no single owner, is about to be transformed into a commodity through bottles, images and a proposed permission regime. Panidubbi's stern expression signals the conflict. The conclusion generates clear dramatic tension: water has spoken memory, while the market seeks a way to close its mouth.

The Unstable Relationship Between Water and Narration

The novel does not make water an omniscient archive. Its voice acquires meaning through the distinct agencies of boatmen, women, children, Gop, Satyavrat and Panidubbi. Many traces remain incomplete, and some names are indistinct. Such incompleteness does not extinguish narrative credibility; it makes the uncertainty inherent in remembrance perceptible. The critical requirement is not to treat mythic testimony supplied by water as equivalent to an external legal or scientific record.

The Chapter's Structural Conclusion

After the concrete distribution of five seedbeds on land, the chapter on water opens an unfixed geography of currents, routes and smells. Soil provides a stable place for a name; water subjects that name to danger and travel. In the following chapter, 'Fire's Testimony', the physical destruction of records will enter the narrative. The connection among these three chapters is thus not a mere recurrence of natural elements but three different procedures through which memory meets conflict: planting, flowing and burning.

Critical Section 211 | Original Chapter 110 — Fire's Testimony

The Paradox of Ash and Letters

The chapter begins with the formulation, “The fire dies out, but the ash bears witness.” After the memory of water, the narrator turns to an agent of destruction that erases paper yet also gives the illumination of a ritual offering. Fire has already been marked in two distinct forms: the open fire of the hearth and rites, and the concealed fire employed to suppress records. To see both merely as a single flame would erase a crucial moral distinction. The narrative consistently preserves the difference between the instrument and the purpose for which it is used.

The Fire at the Archive and Narrative Urgency

Smoke rises at night from the old repository of papers, where copies of tenders, municipal records, the memorial application, Broom's deed of donation and the register of names were kept. Evidence from several institutional routes has been gathered in one place. The blaze therefore threatens more than a building: it threatens to sever the connections among several previously fragmented narratives. Ananya's response, learned in the children's vigil—“Breath first, words afterwards”—becomes a practical test of discipline already established before the emergency.

A Controlled Fire and the Ethical Dilemma of Saving Evidence

Aruni advances with water to extinguish the flames, but Meera wishes to pause for a moment so that traces on the half-burned papers might survive. Devika and Saumya prevent the flames from spreading while a portion in the middle continues to burn within limits. The scene exposes a moral tension in protecting memory: immediate safety and the preservation of evidence do not always sit easily together. Criticism must also acknowledge the danger of this episode: in an actual fire, saving lives would take precedence. The novel constructs the tension as a symbolic scene rather than a model of emergency procedure.

The Concealed Reverse Side of a Burning Page

Behind the official formulation “encroached vacant land” the story reveals a reference to “land valuation of the memorial area.” Fire consumes the paper's outward claim while exposing the language of profit concealed within it. This magical event is a dramatic technique for stripping away the covering of administrative language. The narrative does not scientifically claim that the heat of a fire automatically authenticates

actual documents. Its creative force lies in showing the two faces of procedural terminology.

The Inside Key and the Suspension of Accusation

Gop Kumar discovers that the door was not forced open; it was opened with an inside key. Ananya, Devika and Hemnarayan possessed keys. Hemnarayan is absent, yet the children refuse to pronounce him guilty before learning what happened. This postponement heightens suspense while observing the ethical rule they have practised throughout the novel: listen before attaching an accusation to a name. The narrator does not turn the exposure of crime into a single miraculous solution.

Hemnarayan's Admission and the Pressure of Debt

Found unconscious beside the pond, Hemnarayan recovers and explains that fear of the hospital debts incurred for his son led him to hand over the key. He had imagined the removal of one paper; he had not been told that a fire would be started. This does not cancel his individual responsibility, but it adds debt, inadequate hospital provision and coercive pressure to the chain of causes. The episode speaks to the earlier mule-account and contracting narratives: being an intermediary is not proof of innocence, but the relationship with the principal beneficiary must also be investigated.

Labour as a Penalty in the Vigil over Names

Inspired by Ba, the children assign Hemnarayan a month of night watch and the task of rewriting the partly burned names. They also decide that the question of his debt should be raised at a community hearing. The resulting conception of punishment differs from the earlier logic of revenge. Acknowledging culpability, performing restorative work and making the structural causes of exploitation public proceed together. The narrative nevertheless does not say that a month's service entirely replaces compensation or formal judicial process.

The Incompleteness of the Half-Burned Names

On one sheet only fragments of letters survive, such as “Sar…,” “Uj…” and “Na….” The narrator does not establish with certainty whose three names these were. Ujjwal's mother wishes to receive the charred signs as a remembrance of all those who remain unnamed. The decision resists the temptation to construct a complete biography from a fragmentary text. A stone inscribed “The Half-Burned Names” gives concrete form to respect for incomplete knowledge, and criticism must read it with the same restraint.

Three Portions of Ash and the Reinvestment of Matter

At dawn the ash is divided among three places: beside the stones of names, near the new sprout and in an empty earthen bowl. Matter surviving destruction is thus given renewed places in remembrance, regeneration and possible testimony. The threefold distribution transforms grief over destroyed documents into a dispersed ritual of memory. The fine sensation of warmth in the ash and grains slipping between fingers makes the scene more materially immediate than a merely symbolic declaration.

The Ghost's Double Circle

The old ghost draws two circles in the ash, one inside the other. Characters interpret them as village and Earth, while a possible third circle suggests the distant dream of the nameless planet. The extension of space is symbolic; it would be mistaken to treat it as the announcement of an actual future journey. The circles recreate the repeatedly shifting boundaries of kabaddi. At every crisis, the perimeter of protection acquires a different meaning.

The Arrival of Air after Fire

A child's question—when will the wind speak?—connects the conflagration with the next chapter. The fine dust of ash borne by the air onto people's foreheads provides the narrative transition. The sequence from water to fire and from fire to air is not simply an enumeration of the five elements. Each element reveals a distinct possibility of erasing names and a different method of preserving them. The consequences of this sequence will be tested in the next chapter as an ethics of what circulates through the air.

The Craft of Evidence and a Limited Conclusion

Saumya finds in the ash half a company emblem, a trace of the municipality and a fragment resembling an application code. The words “half” and “resembling” matter: these findings do not establish a complete indictment. By placing several suggestive marks in the same ash, the narrator creates the possibility of a connection, while the scene of formal verification remains to come. If criticism turns such uncertainty into proof of a definite conspiracy, it damages the novel's carefully qualified narrative method.

Critical Section 212 | Original Chapter 111 — The Question of Air

Reconfiguring the Narrative through an Invisible Medium

“The Question of Air” opens with the smoke that moves through the village lanes after the fire in the archive. Soil, water and ash can be held in one's hands; air is harder to contain. The narrator consequently shifts attention from the physical limits of archival preservation to the circulation of information, rumour and humiliation. The central power of the image of air's questioning is that it renders an invisible diffusion perceptible through a sequence of observable events.

The Memory-Laden Smell of Smoke

Instead of merely stinging eyes, the smoke recalls hearths, a grandmother's shawl, the body at the water burial, hospital oxygen and the blue glare of a screen. Bringing five distinct memories together in one smell gives air the power to link several social situations, without claiming that the injuries involved are identical. The sensory metaphor bridges separate narrative strands. Individual recollection and public pollution remain present alongside one another.

Rules for the Vigil over Air

Ananya and the children's circle establish rules against spreading unverified allegations, unauthorised stories about women's lives, mockery of the dead and easy jokes about the suffering of the poor. Air becomes a metaphor for public speech. The vigilance demanded by the Constitution of Names reaches beyond digital screens into the ordinary square, the tea stall and domestic gossip. This expansion moves the novel's ethical question beyond opposition to a single device and into the whole domain of social conversation.

A Small Drama of Rumour at the Tea Stall

A man claims that some names celebrated at the festival of names were false; Ananya asks him for his source. Without staging an exhaustive philosophical examination of evidence, the narrative makes an important change: the heat of dispute becomes a process of listening instead of an altercation. The tea stall turns into a small public forum where speakers are asked to account for their words. Rumour is not automatically pronounced true or false; it is identified as unverified.

Air Enters the Rooms of the Wrongdoers

Across Batuknath's "Forgive me," the ash writes an image of "Listen first." In Chandrapal's cold office appears "Names will not be filtered." Raghav hears his codes and vanished messages echoing within his ears, while "Present" appears upon the glass of Lau's air purifier. One element reveals four different habits of wrongdoing in four enclosed spaces. The editing together of widely separated locations quickens the rhythm of the scene sequence.

The Irony of Mechanical Purity

Lau's imported air purifier registers a particle count of zero, yet the word associated with a name appears on its glass. Technically declared pure, the air is not free of social history. The contrast questions the fantasy of unimpeded control concealed in the language of convenience and safety. Nor can the air-conditioned chill of Chandrapal's office produce moral neutrality. The technological metaphor criticises an absence of social responsibility; it does not establish the general impossibility of scientific air purification.

Flags and the Plurality of Voices

The children make small cloth flags bearing the words truth, names, privacy, labour, water, soil, seeds, fire and air. Their different rustling sounds, determined by the thickness of the cloth, are a distinctive authorial detail: the collective voice is plural rather than uniform. Here "air" is no longer merely an abstract element. It becomes the flutter of cloth made by bodily labour and a sign offered in public.

The Test of Breath and the Game of Confession

This time the boundary for kabaddi is made by air. During the game, a child previously involved in entering fabricated names blurts out, "I entered false names." Discipline is now interwoven with the game's rhythm. The children do not immediately turn the confessor into a spectacle of punishment; after the admission, the child returns to the circle of play. Under this new rule, speaking the truth becomes connected with movement and the continuity of breath.

Air and the Paradox of the Nameless Planet

The dream returns to the image of breath distributed by machines inside a dome. Ira asks how words and memories could survive if breathing itself became something rented out. At this point the narrative joins ownership of environmental resources with the right to communicate. The dome is not an established fact about a real project in the future; it is a warning

image arising from the interwoven strands of the earlier dream and promotional propaganda.

From Sight to Hearing

In "The Question of Air," the natural element is something to be heard rather than seen. The flutter of flags, a child's trembling admission, the memory-arousing smell of smoke and the unseen gap in a window all require the reader to perceive the story through several senses. This construction temporarily distances the narrative from the intensely visual flames of the preceding chapter. Changing the sensory organisation of narration helps sustain variety of rhythm within the novel's extensive form.

The Limits of the Vigil over Air

The rule against spreading unconfirmed statements is necessary. Yet the chapter does not fully settle which reports should be checked, who is empowered to check them, or how disagreement should be distinguished from rumour. The tension between responsible public speech and freedom of expression remains implicit. The text initiates an ethical awareness rather than offering a complete institutional solution. This incompleteness leads naturally into the enlarged questions of the next chapter, "The Emptiness of the Sky."

The Final Unanswered Voice

At night the children leave incense unlit so that the air may retain its own smell. Finally the air itself asks: who will stand guard over breathing? Merely tightening a boundary cannot answer the question. The social discipline of the air-vigil has been established, but control over an invisible resource essential to life remains unresolved. This open ending is the strength of the author's question-led sequence: each element opens its own narrative centre and, carrying the metaphor of a new vigil, invites the next element to speak.

Critical Section 213 | Original Chapter 112 — The Emptiness of the Sky

An Expansive Void and a New Field of Vision

Chapter 112 opens with the experience of seeing the entire sky at once, where the branches of a tree once permitted only glimpses of it. An unobstructed sky usually signifies freedom, but here it seems to descend upon the chest as a weight. By expanding the visual field, the author paradoxically intensifies the gravity of the question. The missing branches, once wounds in the village's history, now expose human beings to a new immensity.

Distinguishing Two Kinds of Emptiness

The chapter's most penetrating narrative invention is its differentiation of two vacant spaces. Official papers put numbers in place of names, empty boxes in place of workers and deleted lines in place of truth: this is an emptiness that swallows. Ananya leaves blank spaces for those whose names have not been found: this is an emptiness that waits. Both appear empty, yet their narrative actions are opposite. “Absence” ceases to have a single meaning and becomes ethically divided.

The Ritual of Looking Up after a Name

The assembly decides to look upward for a moment after each name has been read—without a mantra, a photograph or a performance. This bodily gesture is a different form of silence. Raising the head becomes a symbolic means of sending a name into boundless space; the empty sky serves as a provisional seat for those who have disappeared. The scene's sanctity arises not from institutional authority but from sitting together and acknowledging silence.

The Old Ghost at the Edge of Light

This time the old ghost appears not as smoke but upon the boundary between shadow and light. The figure embodies, at a visible edge, the philosophical dispute over emptiness. The ghost distinguishes a vacancy produced by power from a place made by remembrance. The magical character's words open the memory of social erasure. Rather than treating the ghost as an omniscient and neutral interpreter, it is more appropriate to read the figure as a witness to popular experience.

The Wrongdoers' Discomfort when the Frame Changes

Chandrapal tries to capture points in the sky as data, but the screen displays a limit to downloading. Raghav cannot establish definite proof that his messages have arrived, while the sky over Mithila returns in Lau's glass. These three separate scenes construct a clear opposition. Those who have practised control by turning names into calculations, communications or property now encounter an emptiness that belongs to no institution.

The Artificial Ceiling of the Dream and the Open Earth

In Ananya's dream, the dome of the nameless planet resembles a blue screen. After the recitation of names in Garh Narikel, marks appear on its dream ceiling. This event should not be treated as external astronomical evidence; it is a parallel image of consciousness. The opposition between the actual village's open sky and the dream's controlled ceiling compares possible worlds within the novel. The question of leaving room for remembrance reaches both of them.

Reconstructing Kabaddi in the Sky

Instead of drawing a boundary on the ground, the children stand in a circle and look upward. A child's shadow appears to run upside down across the sky. The miracle changes the rules of play once again: the opposing force to be overcome is not a human body but the vacant place of a name that has not been heard. Listening rather than speed becomes the condition of victory. Thus kabaddi's long-running metaphor moves beyond its original competition toward a more delicate practice of collective remembrance.

A Place for Women's Unspoken Names

Meera sees in the empty sky a place for women whose stories found no room in the household, the court or on a screen. “Place” here means not physical territory but an honourable waiting space for untold narratives. Women's whispers and a faint tremor of stars create a small magical scene. Once more, the novel safeguards the ethical distinction between allowing a story to emerge and publishing it without authority.

The Shared Void of Migration

Ira writes a second letter to children abroad, suggesting that the skies above different cities can offer a similarly open emptiness. The letter returns the reader to the migrant dialogue of Chapter 88. Visual connection becomes a new medium for crossing national distance, but no permanent theory of magical messaging is proposed. Migrant remembrance may involve not only images of the old village but also the sustained practice of listening for names from wherever one lives.

The Sky Inverted in a Drop of Dew

A drop on the new sprout of the stump contains an inverted reflection of the entire sky. This concentrated association of the immense and the minute is the chapter's visual climax. The void that weighed upon the chest becomes something close enough to touch within the drop. By making a single drop bear an image of the whole sky, the author reverses the scale of space: the reach of memory does not depend upon geographical size.

The Final Drumbeat and the Vertical Structure

At the chapter's close, the beat of a drum seems to rise from beneath the earth, and Ba mentions the possibility of an answer from the underworld. The gaze raised toward the sky bends back toward roots. This upward and downward movement makes the narrative a journey of sensation in two directions. Yet the next original chapter is "The Body of Words." It would therefore be wrong to declare that an underworld chapter begins immediately. The actual sequence contains a creative shift between the vertical suggestion and a new test concerning language.

Emptiness Is Not a Complete Solution

Ba's assertion that no one owns the sky is an ethical demand; the specific politics of influence over modern communications, satellites and resources remain unresolved. The novel uses open space as an imaginative resistance to monopolised rights, not as a comprehensive model of legal regulation. Its critical significance lies in reading the scene while recognising that limit: emptiness can become a possibility for remembrance, but the institutional work of defending it has yet to be done.

Critical Section 214 | Original Chapter 113 — The Body of Words

A New Turn from the Sky to Language

After the emptiness of the limitless sky, “The Body of Words” narrows the field of inquiry again, bringing the reader close to five words written on paper. The shift from an immense metaphor to a slate of letters matters, for the narrative asks why saying “present” or “justice” does not itself bring about the labour of presence or an actual judicial outcome. The narrator refuses to let words become disembodied proclamations, joining them instead to the social actions to which they refer.

The Immediate Body of Falsehood and Truth's Long Wait

The opening reflection suggests that falsehood readily acquires a body in files, seals, contracts, tenders and deeds of donation, whereas truth needs time, sweat and attentive listening before it finds one. “Body” functions here as an operative metaphor. It exposes an inequality of time between the outward legitimacy of institutional language and the slow public recognition of victims' experiences. The power of words is tested not in a dictionary but in the objects and actions that carry them.

A Narrative Laboratory of Five Words

At the coconut-leaf school, five words are written: name, present, justice, privacy and Earth. The children are asked what body each word might have. One child calls a name a stone, another a mouth, a third an ear and a fourth time. Four images for a single word produce a scene of multiple meanings. Rather than making the school a one-directional platform for lectures, the narrator fashions a shared creation through questions and answers.

Stone, Ear, Basil, Mirror and Seed

Five empty circles receive a stone, the shape of an ear, a basil leaf, a mirror and a seed. These objects are not permanent, universal symbols: they take their meanings from the characters' earlier experiences. A name engraved on stone may remain only a monument unless spoken. The protection of privacy depends on whose hand holds the mirror. The seed represents the labour of choosing land. The common gathering of these diverse images draws threads from earlier stories together in a new configuration.

The Characters' Right to Interpret

Ira locates Earth's body in the feet that bear weight; Meera locates privacy's body in a mirror under the subject's control; Devika finds the body of presence in the time devoted to listening; Aruni links justice with the living fragrance of basil; and Satyavrat distinguishes stone from voice. No single authorised character delivers the final interpretation of a term. This plurality is an important feature of the novel's communal voice.

The Legal Body and Lifeless Meaning

Satyavrat observes that statutes, orders, judgments and affidavits can acquire strong bodies yet remain dead without compassion. His statement continues the trajectory of his earlier testimony. It does not imply that law is unnecessary; the text expressly demands that the procedures attached to words be tested. The creative principle is that administrative language should yield living consequences, not merely perpetuate a moral disguise.

The Interlude of Ordinary Tea

The tea seller remarks that tea, too, is made of water, leaves, milk, fire, hands and waiting. In this small comic incident, an expansive reflection on language descends into the relations of everyday labour. The vast novel uses the moment to release readers from the fatigue of continually slogan-like formulations. The making of tea gives the metaphor of a word's body domestic accessibility through a material example.

Kabaddi in Accord with Words

As they run, the children now repeat not only “kabaddi” but also “name,” “justice” and “Earth.” Before breath runs out, each player must name an action connected with the body of the word. The game is not a test of vocabulary; it is an exercise in linking utterance with conduct. In this altered round, the ethics of language joins bodily movement to public accountability.

The Disembodied Gleam of the Word “Contract”

At the chapter's end, a ray makes “contract” appear in an empty circle. The other words had objects before them; in front of “contract” there is only brightness. This dramatic discrepancy suggests that a contract without a visible body may nevertheless gain possession of another person's body, land or future. The old ghost's instruction to “look inside the contract's belly” invites the next economic and administrative conflict in a few words.

Distance from a Transcendent Philosophical Discipline

The novel recalls learned texts and Gangesha's questions, but the narratological achievement of this chapter lies in its materialisation of words, the ordering of dialogue, the altered rules of a game and the dramatic appearance of a contract. The scene is not complete proof of any single philosophical theory. Criticism must examine how the narrative takes meaning from professed truth into social performance, rather than suppressing the characters' experiences beneath an imported formal examination of semantics.

The Relationship between Song and the Central Narrative

The opening song celebrating the birth of letters gives words a festive beginning. The main narrative then insists that a newly born word has an incomplete body without action. Celebration and caution thus proceed as parallel voices. Formally, the song bridges the reader to the chapter's principal concern; the prose tests it in actual conflict among characters. The song is consequently not a redundant summary but a distinct linguistic state of feeling alongside critical scrutiny.

The Necessary Question of the Next Chapter

After the gleam of "contract," Chapter 114 will bring "The Soul of Meaning" and the government's "Present Campaign." The novel first demands a body for words and then shows that meaning can be stolen even when the body survives. These paired chapters make the protection of names more difficult. From safeguarding the identity of written words, the narrative moves toward a struggle over the social ownership of meaning.

Critical Section 215 | Original Chapter 114 — The Soul of Meaning

Correct Letters and the Theft of Meaning

Following “The Body of Words,” “The Soul of Meaning” introduces a subtle reversal. On the banners of the “Present Campaign” in the market square, the letters are accurate, their vowel signs correct and their design attractive, yet the word originally used as a response by the bereaved families has become a promotional sign. Meaning can therefore be destroyed without erasing a word: moving it into a new institutional arrangement is enough. The narrative conflict concerns neither spelling nor orthography, but the right of address and the ownership of context.

The Materiality of the Pennants

Ananya's inspection of the stiff crackle of new cloth and the fresh smell of ink makes the opening scene unusually specific. The impression of ethical emptiness beneath visually correct letters connects the abstract claim of a “stolen word” to the reader's senses. The repetition of one word upon paper, caps, bags and teacups forms a montage of consumerist circulation. With every repetition, the word travels farther from the original grief.

Three Meanings of One Word in Three Circles

At the school, “present” is placed in three settings: the reply of a bereaved family, an official campaign and a wall on the nameless planet of the dream. The first holds tears, the second accounts and the third emptiness. The narrator gives the same phonetic form three distinct circumstances of action. Without a heavy lecture, this comparative arrangement lets readers watch the social construction of meaning. The characters' voices, an advertisement and a dream occupy different narrative levels; the criticism preserves that difference.

The Screen of a Positive Image

On the municipality's cap, the severed Channa stump is replaced by a fully green grove, water burial by festive greenery, and the crocodile disappears. In the name of creating a “positive image,” the site of the wound is being erased. Linking this to her bodily history, Meera recalls that violations of privacy were sometimes called protection and the enforcement of silence was called propriety. Her recollection shifts the episode from an external critique of government publicity into the felt experience of individual humiliation.

Measuring a Word's Worth by the Victim's Time

Satyavrat tests the meaning of "justice" by whether it saves the time of the injured person. Following years of postponement, the word may remain while its living substance has perished. Here the earlier experience of the Constitution of Names becomes a linguistic test. Gajendra Thakur writes not merely about the shape of a word but about its consequences over time. Justice, safety, development and heritage acquire different meanings through the experiences of different wounded people.

The Community Theatre of the "Test of Meaning"

In the evening, people inscribe development, donation, justice, respect, safety, heritage and present on stones and recount their experiences. A labourer's daughter remembers her father drowned near a bridge pier; Devika exposes the commercial form of the deed of donation; Meera remains silent when safety is discussed. This arrangement of voices makes the characters judges of meaning through lived experience, not examples illustrating a dictionary. Silence, too, remains a legitimate participant in the test.

Meaningless Presence on the Dream Planet

In the night's dream, a mechanical voice says, "All attendance recorded," yet no individual name receives an answer. The repeated Devanagari word becomes an emblem of an extreme absence of meaning. This dream is not authenticated news from an extraterrestrial civilisation; it stages mentally the difference between artificial registration and living relationships. Through this symbol, the narrative portrays the export of a word and the failure to transfer its meaning.

The Inherited Question of "Propriety"

Batuknath's child writes "propriety" and asks whom its meaning should be sought from. Meera replies: from those who were silenced in the name of propriety. What matters in this small scene is the emergence of questioning within a family inheritance. Merely obeying paternal language cannot constitute the younger generation's judgment. It must engage with speakers whose lives were suppressed. Reading a single word afresh opens a new entrance into social history.

The Official Leaflet of Reinterpretation

A rain-soaked government leaflet proposes renaming "water burial" as "water heritage," "ghost kabaddi" as "folk theatre," "the dead" as "elements of the past," and "victims" as "stakeholders." These formal substitutions connect with the earlier tenders and the collection of digital data. The violence lies not only in erasing an event but also in making it

seem innocuous through administratively neutral language. The chapter repeatedly presses the question of how greatly the voice of accountability can be diminished by a change of name.

The Lengthening Shadow as a Warning

While the leaflet is being read, the stump's shadow lengthens although the sun stands overhead. This contrary image of nature becomes the community's response to the killing of meaning. The old ghost's whisper offers a magical interpretation of the event, but the actual social danger is already plain in the leaflet's list. The narrative joins these two levels without making one a mere copy of the other.

The Difficulty of Shared Ownership of Meaning

A merchant asks how slogans can be made under such rules; a leader claims a shared entitlement to words. Ba distinguishes sharing from plunder. A delicate question remains unresolved: public words belong to everyone, yet changing their context without the experience of those injured by them can become exploitation. The novel does not convert the conflict into a complete legal theory. It keeps the tension alive as part of a popular discussion.

The Next Transition, toward the Throat

At the end, the crumbling printed letters leave colour on a child's palm. The image of stolen meaning thus returns to the body. The next original chapter is “The Vigil over the Throat,” in which the ownership of voice is questioned behind the written letter. Along this sequence, the method of appropriation changes by degrees: turn names into numbers, meaning into publicity, and the voices that utter those words into property under recording rights. The narrative transition is clear but deliberately unresolved.

Critical Section 216 | Original Chapter 115 — The Vigil over the Throat

The Body of Voice and the Appeal of Preservation

After “The Soul of Meaning,” a recording device called the “Archive of the Voices of Names” is placed beside the village square. It presents itself as a means of preserving voices: future generations could listen to the recitation of names, an apparently useful proposal. The small print, however, grants the institution rights over the recordings. The narrator constructs a dramatic struggle between the genuine wish to safeguard voices and a concealed claim to ownership. The device is not itself an absolute villain; the unequal terms of the agreement give it its political body.

The Greedy Ears of the Brass Box

To Ananya, the machine's gleaming face and little openings resemble the ears of a creature in darkness. Touch discloses a difference between the brass surface warmed by sunlight and the mechanical heat within. Bodily warmth and the box's warmth are not the same. Through this fine sensory contrast, readers feel the difference between listening by a living person and technological storage. The name later given to the machine, “Ears of Greed,” develops out of this first visual image.

The Unequal Language of the Agreement

The guardians of recorded voices invoke “community interest” and “collective consent,” while Meera and Ananya ask who controls each individual's name and voice. Representing collective suffering does not abolish the bounds of personal permission. Here the contest over rights advances beyond data, names and pictures to the slight tremor of a throat and variations in pronunciation. The vocabulary of institutional coordination proves distinct from the consent of the victim.

Ujjwal's Mother's Quiet Pronunciation

At the beginning of the recitation, Ujjwal's mother chooses to say her son's name softly. Asked to sit before the machine, she replies that if the box cannot hear a quiet voice, the box is deaf. This brief exchange reverses the criteria for judging vocal “quality.” Unequal volume, a trembling tone and the speaker's own decision matter more within the novel than the machine's uniform standards. The woman's reply is not merely mockery; it is an assertion of authority over her voice.

The Broken Speech of a Toothless Elder

In the second recitation, an old person's speech breaks because so many teeth are missing. The recording staff ask for clearer pronunciation, but the elder refuses to alter a dead person's name for the machine's convenience. Narratologically, the episode challenges the power to classify particular speech as a linguistic "error." A dignified archive must admit differences among voices; otherwise its recording procedures will erase the very speakers whose throats have already been changed by age or bereavement.

When Weeping Becomes a Name

A child's throat closes as he attempts to pronounce the name of his grandfather lost at the bridge. The machine asks for clear articulation, but Ananya recognises weeping itself as a form of testimony. A drop of water on the green indicator and the silent child's tears form an intensely emotional image. To say metaphorically that the machine "could not grasp the meaning" is not the whole criticism. The actual question is why the act of archiving should place a demand for clear pronunciation upon the person speaking.

The Price of Emotional Sound and the Market's Entry

The machine crackles while recording sobs, and Chandrapal's remark that "emotional sound is valuable" becomes the decisive moment. A voice that belongs within relationships formed around names is about to be converted into a new category of marketable data. Devika immediately makes the statement public. The contrast between the child's partial silence and the trader's explicit calculation of profit provides the dramatic tension of the scene.

Living Ears versus an Archive with an Owner

Meera proposes rules requiring a family's permission for names, recognition of the weeping person's rights and rejection of institutional ownership. Satyavrat intervenes to argue that present rights should not be taken away under the pretext of preservation for the future. The prose does not forbid recording forever; it insists upon a sequence: "Listening first, collecting afterwards." Removing the equipment is a temporary decision. The question of an equitable archive remains open.

A Diversity of Throats and a Collective Rhythm

That night people sit close together without the machine. One voice trembles, another tongue falters, another speaker pauses in tears. Yet these unequal voices create a communal rhythm like the breaths taken during kabaddi. The author forms relationships among different throats rather

than composing a uniform chorus. Community, in this scene, means not speaking identically but acquiring the capacity to hear one another amid difference.

The Embodied Nature of Listening in Ba's Words

Ba says that a box can hear, but its stomach cannot ache. This is not a literal account of a machine; it is a compressed metaphor for the ethical distinction between sympathetic listening and storage. A living listener bears the burden of relationships, loss and obligation behind a name. The narrator unfolds this embodied condition of social knowledge through the experience of an elderly woman. Wisdom outside formal terminology once again occupies the centre of narration.

Naming the "Ears of Greed": A Reversal

Before the machine is taken away, Ananya has its name recorded as well: "The Ears of Greed came, never learned to listen, and returned." The procedure of the vigil over names is thereby applied even to an opposing object. Instead of allowing a wrongdoer or instrument to remain a nameless threat, its use and consequences are named. The record serves as a warning for the future rather than a celebration of immediate victory.

Listening, Technology and the Possibility of Coexistence

The novel initially acknowledges a need to preserve voices through technology, but suspends this programme because of unfair conditions concerning rights. Criticism must maintain that distinction. A sound archive is not inherently theft; it becomes exploitative under unauthorised ownership and greed. Detailed arrangements for proper consent, remuneration for labour, shared decisions and a right to withdraw are not yet fully established in the text. This act of vigilance opens a practical future rather than completing one.

The Next Sign: "Writing"

On the final page, the word "writing" glows. The narrator indicates that when voices cannot be imprisoned, the next claim of control may be made over language, printing and texts. This anticipation turns the end of the current cumulative sequence into the threshold of the next chapter. Pressure changes its form, from erased names to meanings, from meanings to throats and from throats to writing. Sections 209–216 therefore come to rest not at a full stop but at the ordered beginning of new questions.

Inter-Sectional Discussion — From Soil to the Throat

The narrative of Chapters 108–115 appears as a continuous sequence. Soil raises questions of rights over seeds and the distribution of land; water turns names from a fixed archive into travelling routes; fire destroys documents yet makes ash a witness; air asks who is responsible for speech and rumour; sky distinguishes an emptiness made by erasure from an emptiness that waits. This is not merely a decorative progression through the five natural elements. Each element exposes a different institutional weakness in the vigil over names.

A second arc of the sequence emerges in Chapters 113–115. From the body of words, the narrative moves to the soul of meaning and then to the vigil over the throat. The same word, "present," acquires different meanings in a family's response, a government advertisement and a dream scene on the nameless planet. Possessing a written word does not secure its meaning; even when that meaning survives, an institution may appropriate the rights to record its voice. The question of rights that began with soil does not end in the throat. It returns in a still subtler form.

In terms of focalisation, the narrator does not depend on a single omniscient viewpoint. Dhirmati's palm, the water-dweller's aqueous vision, Hemnarayan's bondage to debt, Meera's protection of privacy, Devika's caution with information, Satyavrat's written rules and Ananya's decisions as a child all disclose the same community from different human situations. These characters also translate the voices of natural substances into social conduct. Consequently, the chains of social causation are not entirely obscured by the magical scenes.

The recurring image of kabaddi provides a distinctive structural thread. The vigilance over names first takes place within a line in the soil, then a circle of water, a ring of ash, a lengthened breath of air and an empty space in the sky. In "The Body of Words," the rules of a turn change so that players must identify what a word does. The critical value of repetition lies in these changing rules; the recurrence of the word alone cannot explain the movement of the narrative.

The outcomes of all eight chapters remain limited and conditional. Seeds are sown in five fields, but enduring rights to the crops are unsettled. A new map of water is drawn, but the trade in bottled reverence begins. One link in the fire's chain of culpability emerges, but the entire criminal network remains unjudged. Rules about air are adopted, but the boundary between rumour and dissent remains open. The emptiness of the sky is revealed, but its defence is uncertain. The recording device is removed, yet

no just system for preserving voices in the long term has been developed. The narrative advances because these problems are unfinished.

The nameless planet of dreams, the crocodile symbol, speaking soil, letters upon water and magical ash in the original text have been read as narrative possibilities and symbolic events. They have not been presented as self-authenticating evidence of external historical facts, scientific observations or actual judicial decisions. This method, conscious of its evidentiary limits, keeps the distinct registers of social reality and magical narration visible across the long novel.

The appearance of "writing" at the end of Chapter 115 announces a new field of claims. After the contest over institutional ownership of voices, the narrative opens the possibility of further control through printing, texts, archives and language. The first portion of this new cumulative sequence therefore ends in an ordered transition: from the memory of nature to the memory of language, and from linguistic memory toward the coming struggle over writing.

Critical Section 217 | Original Chapter 116 — The Inheritance of Silence

From the Vigil over the Throat to the Vigil over Silence

After Chapter 115's struggle over the recording of voices, Chapter 116 brings silence to the centre of the narrative. This is not a departure from the subject but a rigorous examination of the limits of protection already established. A community that prevents the theft of a person's voice must now recognise that compelling everyone to speak can itself constitute another form of dispossession. The author accomplishes this transition through an unusual day of silence at the school.

The Dual Nature of Silence: Wrongdoing and Right

The narrator initially distinguishes two social meanings of silence. Satyavrat's earlier silence was culpable because he failed to speak despite witnessing injustice; the silence of an injured person, by contrast, may be a decision to protect their body and memory. This difference does not remain an abstract slogan. Satyavrat himself stands with empty hands, illustrating its difficulty through his experience. The character's previous wrongdoing lends moral weight to the emerging principle.

The Scenic Arrangement of the Empty Bowl

Devika places an empty bowl at the centre of the school. What the narrator sees in it is not an object but the possibility of listening. The bowl becomes a concrete focus of the scene, repeatedly drawing the gaze of the characters. Later, Ujjwal's mother does not fill it with her tears: her act of preserving silence constitutes a dramatic reversal. An empty object changes abstract grief into a dignified presence rather than a public performance.

An Active Pause in the Narrative

On the first day, the teacher, Ananya and Ira also sit without speaking. The pause does not halt the narrative; it establishes new conditions for listening. Earlier, the novel abounded in dialogue, declarations, documents and folk songs. Now the duration of silence compels the reader to attend to the minute signs offered by bodies, leaves, stones and the empty bowl. By slowing the pace, the narrative expands the range of possible expression.

The Voice-Collection Contract and Its Small Print

A sound-collecting group from the city promises to preserve the oral heritage, but the leaflet's small print conceals permission for future enhanced presentations. This documentary tension recalls the earlier

tendering of memory and the memorial application. The distance between the public language of consent and the minute conditions of control becomes a narrative of social violence. Meera confronts the terms of the contract with the bodily right of a person to their own voice.

Meera Establishes the Voice as Part of the Body

Through Meera's question, sound ceases to be merely a collectable object and becomes a relationship to a person. The ability to imitate a voice may demonstrate technical expertise; it does not establish a right to that voice. Her experience of violations of privacy makes this intervention consistent with her character. The narrator does not allow her statement to remain a disembodied theoretical maxim: the physical memory of earlier fear stands behind it.

Chandrapal and Raghav: The Failure of Their Media

Even in silence Chandrapal recognises an opportunity to trade in voices, but the drying of his throat interrupts his commercial perspective. Raghav sees prospects for sound collection on his device, yet the messages become soundless. The two scenes establish distinct focalisations within characters associated with wrongdoing. The narrator does not announce their immediate reform. The conflict between ingrained commercial habits and emerging self-knowledge remains unresolved.

A Deliberately Blank Page in the New Register

For the first time the register used for reading names includes a page headed “Those who did not speak, but were present.” An ordinary register demands information to fill its spaces; here the decision to preserve a blank space is itself an archival act. The emptiness protects time and a person's rights instead of imposing conjecture upon an unknown individual. The earlier practice of guarding names thus makes room within itself for uncertainty.

The Arrival of a Girl Who Does Not Speak

The boy who had removed his mask during the procession of false ghosts brings his sister, who has been without a voice since birth. She draws lines on a leaf and places it in the bowl. Her introduction is not simply a mark of deprivation: her initiative in joining the game alters the collective rules. The focal centre shifts from those who explain her from outside to the girl who chooses her own means of expression.

The Audible Paradox of Silent Kabaddi

The girl begins playing without uttering “kabaddi.” Remarkably, once the dominant voice is absent, the tapping of feet, the rustle of earth and the

friction of clothing become distinct. The narrator presents not an absolute absence of sound but the emergence of secondary sounds when the principal one disappears. Through this sensory rearrangement, silence becomes a multifaceted experience of hearing. The game develops a new grammar of collective understanding.

A Mother's Private Time of Mourning

Ujjwal's mother places a hand on the blank page and expresses an experience in which her son asks nothing of her. Amid the earlier digital reproductions of death and recurring commemorations, this sentence creates an independent moment of mourning. The maternal character is released from the perpetual obligation to testify publicly. The text preserves this moment as her own private time of grief; it does not declare her grief resolved.

The Dot of Silence and Magical Realism

A black dot appears from the smoke of an oil lamp in the corner of the open, empty page. The children call it the dot of silence. The significance of this small marvel lies less in its unusual origin than in its social implication: even the residual trace of what has not been written should be preserved. The arrival of a circle of silence in Lau Kin-Hung's dream links the local scene to a distant commercial network without converting the dream into an externally verified fact.

The Beginning of the Next Debt

The vigil over silence appears to have succeeded, but the chapter does not rest on that success. The name that has been heard and the debt incurred through protecting it prepare the question of the following chapter. In this structure every solution generates a further obligation that has not yet been answered. Chapter 116's achievement is to make the practice of safeguarding memory capable of defending the freedom not to speak as well as the freedom to speak.

Critical Section 218 | Original Chapter 117 — The Debt of Memory

From a Name Heard to Work That Must Be Done

From its opening sentence, Chapter 117 makes a name that has been heard into a debt. The familiar economic meaning of debt belongs to the village's experience of moneylenders, sharecropping, banks and mortgaging. The author redefines the word to indicate the responsibility that arises from remembrance. Accordingly, this is not merely a chronicle of memory: the plot demands work after the reading of names. The transfer of meaning within a single word is the chapter's principal narrative movement.

The Question Written in Charcoal on the Wall

The children write on the school wall, asking who will bear the debt incurred by the names they have heard. The friction of charcoal, crumbling lime and roughness of the letters turn a philosophical proposition into a physical action. The question becomes an instruction for collective work rather than wall decoration. The wall does not replace an official archive; it establishes the local right to inscribe a question beyond the boundaries of that archive.

A Polyphonic Search for Names from House to House

In Ira's exercise, each child attempts to bring from home a name formerly spoken as an insult or entirely suppressed. Searches through old trunks, account books and the spaces beneath household storage create parallel domestic museums of memory. No single narrator relates the entire history; the children bring information from different social fissures. This collective mode of narration makes the novel's extensive social world credible and polyphonic.

The Incomplete History of the Woman Called Charmakarni

One child brings the designation “Charmakarni,” but cannot discover the woman's full name. The caste-marking description has survived while the individual has disappeared. The narrator does not fill this absence with an easy conjecture. Meera protects a blank space by drawing a red circle around it. Here lies the first difficult test of the debt of memory: it is easy to express sympathy for an unknown woman, but harder to acknowledge the history of not knowing her name.

The Narrative of Honour and an Inconvenient Life

The celebration of Gangesha's learning stands beside the absence of the woman whose identity has been confined to caste. The child's question does not pass judgment on a classical scholarly dispute. It exposes the choice of whose names history has preserved and whose it has not. At the level of criticism, what matters is not a claim to establish objective historical fact, but the unequal relation the narrative constructs between the speaker who remembers and the character consigned to silence.

Gop's Records: An Inverted Accounting of Debt

Gop Kumar displays old accounts in which the victims' expenses stand where the plunderers should be, absence appears where the dead should be recorded, and procedure replaces responsibility. This archival inversion is a recurring technique of the novel. An account book ceases to be neutral evidence; its classifications themselves become the subject of conflict. The reader sees how social power decides who is to be called a debtor.

One Concrete Action for Each Name

The children establish a rule: every act of reading a name must be linked to work—dignity and safety for labourers, safeguards against deception for defrauded young people, protection of privacy for women, shared meals for those oppressed by caste, and rights to water for the river's victims. The specificity of this list matters. A single universal garland cannot address every suffering; each narrative wound demands a different social response. Reading names becomes a planned sequence of actions.

The Narrative Trap in the Language of a Debt-Relief Scheme

An unfamiliar official arrives with a leaflet for a "Memory-Debt Relief Scheme." A family may receive an honorarium only if it accepts the authorised memorial narrative. The monetary transaction attempts to convert free remembrance of grief into a controlled story. The word "relief" reverses the title's moral significance: when victims are paid to relinquish their own account, the debt is not discharged; its owner changes.

The Uncomfortable Position of Batuknath and Chandrapal

Following his belated apology, Batuknath begins to understand that tears alone do not discharge a debt. For Chandrapal, the donation box can become a new form of the old percentage-based commission. Raghav's network wants to convert the debt of memory into images and schemes. At each of these centres, transformation is precarious rather than final. The narrator maintains a distance between a wrongdoer's admission and institutional change.

The Attempt to Suppress Questions in the Name of Propriety

An elderly man invokes “propriety” to oppose placing the blank space for Charmakarni beside Gangesha's name. In this episode, propriety emerges not as a means of organising discussion but as a demand that the invisible woman be pushed aside again. The children's response gives the crocodile metaphor a new social meaning: an aquatic creature chews flesh, while caste-defined propriety chews memory. This redistribution of metaphor supplies the chapter with its critical edge.

Kabaddi's Line Becomes a Thread of Responsibility

During the evening game, fine lines run from each stone bearing a name towards the players. This magical image makes the community's debt, discussed throughout the day, perceptible on the body. Previously, the line in kabaddi marked a boundary; here it carries the weight of social relationships. The game's familiar structure remains intact while the meaning of its rules changes, allowing repetition in a long narrative to become a form of development.

The Wet Leaflet and the Unanswered Question

At midnight the leaflet for the relief scheme becomes damp, its seal growing indistinct, while the words “Whose relief?” remain clear. The scene destabilises the administrative assurance. The narrative offers no determinate judicial outcome yet; the author's question preserves the conflict for what follows. This unresolved ending gives the chapter its direction: remembrance does not necessarily produce compassion by itself, but may initiate the difficult work of responsibility.

Critical Section 219 | Original Chapter 118 — The Right to the Body

The Material Limits of Protecting Memory

Chapter 118 connects the debt of memory with rights over the body. Dead bodies, living women, workers' tools, hands humiliated by caste, private photographs and fragments of bone belong to different kinds of relationships. Yet in the language of museums they begin to become a single category of "collectable objects." Through this inventory, the author exposes the brutal flattening performed by an institutional gaze. The central question follows naturally: who will determine the limits of preservation?

The Astonishing Classification of the Heritage Inventory

The inventory brings together root-soil, floodwater samples, clothes, bone-like fragments, women's recollections and workers' implements. As its entries are read, every name opens a different question of dignity and permission. The paper becomes a principal object of opposition within the novel: it treats unequal, living relationships as equivalent objects for collection. Without a sermon, the narrator makes the danger of this equalisation visible.

Meera's Bodily Memory and Fear

Meera speaks publicly of rights, yet the ringing of an unfamiliar telephone or a raised camera makes her hands grow cold. The author does not turn her into an emblem of fearlessness; the wound of experience remains in her body. This distinction preserves the psychological continuity of her character. The rules of privacy arise here from lived experience rather than from the mere announcement of an abstract ideal.

Broom's "Preservation" and Devika's Counterstatement

An outside representative calls the collection an act of preservation. Devika compares it with an exhibition that charges admission for the sight of suffering. The conflict in their dialogue concerns the meanings of words, but its practical consequence rests on the consent of the dead person's family. The narrative does not make modern technology or collecting inherently villainous; it identifies collection without rights as a medium of social violence. Maintaining this distinction is essential to a balanced reading of the chapter.

Aruni's Bridge Plans and the Absence of Bodies

Aruni sees workers' tools in the heritage inventory, but no provision for the workers' families to give permission. He recalls the measurements of the old bridge, in which human bodies had vanished into lines and numbers. The engineer's memory becomes the focal centre of the scene. The prose connects the earlier account of the bridge disaster to the present proposal for collecting objects, revealing a recurring structural failure across apparently different episodes.

A Child's Hand and the Ethical Restraint of Consent

Ananya first asks the children to look at their own hands. The hand can write a name; the same hand becomes that of a thief rather than a guardian if it touches clothing, takes a photograph or lifts bones without permission. This fine regulation of touch checks the easy heroism of the narrative. Saying "We are saving it" does not, by itself, confer rights over another person's body. That is the chapter's practical conclusion.

Remembering the Women's Night Assembly

Meera rereads the rules established at the earlier women's night assembly. This return to a story within the story allows the long novel's earlier struggles to support the present scene. The narrator protects women's right to speak and their decision not to speak. The refusal to give exhaustive details of private weeping is itself a narrative choice: the withheld description functions as a respectful boundary.

The Camera in the Leatherworkers' Neighbourhood and the Elder Woman's Objection

The camera of an outside team arriving to document folk culture moves first across a doorway, then hands, implements and faces. An elderly woman asks whether observing labour and selling humiliation are the same thing. The scene is constructed through a progressive camera-gaze; with every fresh frame the question of ownership grows sharper. Resistance lies not in the volume of the character's voice but in the conditions under which she will allow herself to be seen.

Five Rules of the Code of the Body

The school records rules affirming the primary rights of the person who inhabits a body, the family-related dignity of the dead, the rejection of caste humiliation, restrictions on unauthorised claims made by research tourism, and respect for the silence of a body that cannot speak. The significance of these provisions lies in their local formulation. Characters derive principles from difficult incidents; they do not merely imitate a

ready-made statute. The narrative does not claim any rule will settle every circumstance.

Satyavrat's Limited Participation

Satyavrat Mehta recalls his former legal arguments in which bodily fear, labour and humiliation had been reduced to "cases." He does not rise like a hero to proclaim the rules; instead, he adds a brief sentence to Ananya's page. His position, seated behind the others, recalls his previous wrongdoing. His transformation emerges not from concentrating authority in his hands, but from the repeated practice of learning to listen.

The Evening Ritual of Returning Objects Home

Clothes that were to be placed in a display case are exposed to sunlight and returned to the families' houses; root-soil is restored to its original place. This reverse journey opposes the one-way movement of objects into a museum. The event the narrative foregrounds is not the acquisition of things but the restoration of relationships. The smell of the clothes and warmth of sunlight release the scene from the abstraction of a declaration of rights.

The Page that Opens by Itself in the Caste Register

On the final night, the old caste register at the revenue office opens of its own accord. The magical sign does more than produce fear. Once a universal code of bodily rights has been formulated, conflict with inherited modes of classification becomes inevitable. The narrator signals that prospective conflict through a living object—the old register. In this way, the seed of the next chapter's caste struggle is planted in advance.

Critical Section 220 | Original Chapter 119 — The Body of Labour

From the Individual Body to the Labouring Body

Chapter 118 established bodily privacy and the limits of touch; Chapter 119 brings those principles to the workplace. The story moves from preserving the names of the dead to the wages, rest, water and safety of living workers. This development is narratively necessary: if people possess rights over their bodies, those rights remain incomplete without protection of their labour and health where they work.

The Opening Structure of Three Objects

Before Aruni lie a torn worker's shoe, a fingernail embedded in cement, and a wage slip marked with a number. In this trio the absence of the body and the remnants of its labour become visible together. Each object supplies a distinct sensory or social clue: the shoe suggests touch, the nail injury, and the slip institutional forgetting. The narrator concentrates an extensive history of labour into a few concrete signs.

The Testimony of Jhagaru Mistri's Wife

Jhagaru Mistri fell near a bridge pier, but the accident report recorded him as absent from work. His wife's statement uses the memory of domestic labour to expose the official record as false. She recalls how the hands that sustained the family's hearth were denied even a record of attendance on the day of death. This precise contradiction gives visible form to the clash between living community memory and bureaucratic categories.

The Numerical Violence of the Muster Roll

Gop's file lists forty-seven men, nine women and three others, but gives no names. Without names, the count reduces labouring people to numbers alone. Gop's recognition that securely stored data do not necessarily mean secure human beings marks an essential step in his development. Critically, the prose does not demand that these figures be taken as an independently verified census. Its emphasis falls on the contradictions in the selective language of counting.

Bhagelu Paswan's Two Geographies of the Bridge

Bhagelu tells a story about his father: all the workers built the same bridge, but caste divided their lines for eating and drinking. Publicly, the bridge is an architectural structure that joins places; at the building site, it maps social segregation. This contradictory spatial arrangement makes material development and the humiliation of its workers visible together. The prose

locates the contradiction in a character's testimony rather than in a disembodied generalisation.

Engineer Aruni's Self-Reproach

Aruni studies the plans of the old accident alongside documents describing conditions of work. He cannot simply criticise a culpable contractor and absolve himself. His status as an engineer obliges him to confront his responsibility for the missing names. Accordingly, his focalisation remains frequently silent and concentrated on objects. His capacity for action appears in the difficult admission of responsibility, not in a sudden miracle of rescue.

Renaming "Unskilled" Workers as "Knowers of the Soil"

The children call those classified by the administration as "unskilled" by a new name: "knowers of the soil." This linguistic act of renaming a profession exposes the unequal valuation of practical ability. Yet the reader must also recognise that changing a name does not automatically change a wage. Here the chapter presents linguistic repair and economic rights as necessary complements rather than interchangeable achievements.

Concrete Conditions for New Construction

The heritage project proposes local employment. Aruni asks for contracts bearing workers' names, Devika for wages paid on time, Meera for medical treatment, and Satyavrat for a public inscription of labour rights. When different characters address different questions to the same proposal, the meeting becomes polyphonic. The government project is not reduced to a single villainous sentence; specific gaps in its implementation generate the conflict of the plot.

Labouring Bodies and Mule Accounts: A Metaphorical Correspondence

Bhagelu connects workers' sweat, bodies and deaths with accounts that enrich other people. Chandrapal's digital "mule account" reappears metaphorically in the bodily context of labour exploitation. This correspondence joins otherwise separate strands of the long novel, without collapsing fraud and wage exploitation into the same incident. In both cases, the recurring manoeuvre is to keep an intermediary protected while separating the actual producers from control over what their efforts yield.

Reading the Name Together with the Work Performed

At the evening reading of names, each worker's name is accompanied by a specific task: casting a bridge pier, pushing a boat, hauling an oxygen cylinder, or carrying a dead body home. Such a catalogue prevents the dead

from being defined solely by the scene of their death. The narrative does not sell an individual's usefulness; it makes a person's contribution to communal life worthy of remembrance. Labour becomes a living grammar of names.

The Ambivalent Ritual of Washing Feet

In the final scene, children bring water to wash the cracked feet of workers. As dust and cement are removed, the map of years of fissures in their skin emerges. The text explicitly refuses to call this worship. That reservation matters: the honour accorded to work must not be elevated into supernatural sanctity so that practical questions of wages and rest disappear. The reality of bodies remains protected from the decorative grandeur of ritual.

An Empty Stone and the Future of Invisible Labour

At the end, a stone is set aside for workers who labour but remain unseen. This vacancy enters into dialogue with the earlier blank page of silence and Charmakarni's incomplete name. In the long narrative, an empty place has become a recurring symbol in its own right. By leaving the question of social invisibility open to later chapters, the stone prevents the novel from claiming that it has already produced a complete register of workers.

Critical Section 221 | Original Chapter 120 — The Body of Justice

A Question Moving Out of the Workers' Stones

Chapter 120 opens with the warmth of the stones associated with the preceding reading of workers' names. Stones inscribed with names are warm, while the unnamed stone is wet with dew. The scene transfers justice from the written record into the medium of sensation. What form will justice itself take for those whose bodies have disappeared? The chapter's answer is not a prepared judgment on paper but a communal process of making a body from clay.

Distinguishing an Idol from a Body

The opening proposition contrasts an idol that demands worship with a body that demands accountability. The narrator sustains this distinction throughout the chapter. A proposal arises to turn the potter's clay figure into an object of worship; instead, it is given an ear for listening and an empty chest. The conflict between a memorial's stillness and the movement of living human pain thus takes a material form.

The Voice of an Elderly Woman Labourer at the Centre

As the meeting begins, an elderly woman labourer says that justice must be capable of enduring the smell of sweat. The narrative gives her speech special authority, because without her experience the conventional language of justice would remain without a body. Ba extends the statement into a sequence of smells—milk, ash, mud, blood and tears. These sensory images test social theory rather than simply standing in for it.

Rereading the Bridge Plan Through Touch

Aruni spreads the old bridge plan on the ground. Families place their hands at the spots where the workers' feet once stood. The scene changes the mode of narration: a plan once treated as a copy of technical signatures becomes a tactile surface bearing living memory. Marking the absence of feet with hands effects an archival restoration. The paper is not destroyed; the order and manner in which it is read are changed.

Gop's Decision to Close the File

Gop Kumar opens his files on payments, accidents and arrears, but the children first ask him to listen to the feet. His decision to close the file does not reject knowledge. It accepts a change in focal centre. In this small act a character oriented towards data recognises the limitations of his archive.

The narrative treats documents as necessary while refusing to make them the only arbiters above the human body.

An Ant's Movement on the Unnamed Stone

An ant moves among the letters on the stone marked “Name not found,” then pauses in an empty space. The event is minute, yet through it the narrator changes the scale of the search. After immense institutional decisions, the movement of a tiny creature becomes a centre of uncertainty. The ant's actual movement is not presented as an omniscient witness; it becomes a visible instance of the characters' desire to interpret signs.

One Body Made from Soil Collected in Many Places

The potter brings soil from the banks of the Kamala, the bridge pier, the Channa stump, Ujjwal's home and the pond associated with the water-dweller. Combining these five sources gathers distinct narrative injuries into one figure. Yet kneading them together does not erase their particular locations: the name of every source is spoken aloud. The composite figure evokes community while preserving the separateness of local memories.

The Woman Worker's Palm and the Engineer's Shared Responsibility

Women workers leave impressions in the clay with their bangles, burned skin and cracked fingers. Aruni hesitates to put down his engineer's hand. A woman worker tells him that without the hand implicated in the error, the body brought forward for repair will remain crooked. The exchange makes the admission of wrongdoing a demand for active work. Both the oppressed and the responsible leave marks on the final figure, without thereby becoming morally equivalent.

Satyavrat, Asked to Put His Ear to the Clay

Satyavrat wants to leave the impression of his pen. Ba asks him instead to press his ear against the clay. This is another reversal in his characterisation: someone who has spent so long writing justice must first undergo the bodily exercise of listening. The narrator offers no formal proclamation of forgiveness. The image of an inclined ear marks the character's continuing education.

A Figure Without Gender or Office

By evening, the clay body is neither male nor female, neither a deity nor a judge. One ear touches the ground, its hands face the water, its feet point towards the bridge and the stump, and the chest remains empty. Its arrangement is also a map of narrative space. Justice is not confined to one

face or a high seat; it turns towards the relations of the wider world. The empty chest reserves a future place for the unnamed.

The Bronze Proposal and the Temptation of Consumption

Broom's representative proposes casting the figure in bronze, enclosing and lighting it, and charging admission to the installation. Chandrapal imagines a facility for adding names digitally; Raghav wants to manufacture a replica. All three interventions seek to make pliant clay into a controlled, saleable and fixed object. By bringing different media and their shared commercial gaze to the same scene, the narrator clarifies the connections between the networks of opposition.

A Crack Produced by the Empty Stone

At midnight the empty stone of the unknown worker is placed on the figure's chest. The clay cracks and a drop of dew emerges. The potter does not regard the crack as a defect, but calls it a way for the voice inside to come out. The narrative function of this magical moment is to remove justice from the status of an unbroken idol and make it incomplete and capable of listening. If the figure were utterly complete, where could the unnamed find a place? The question remains alive within the image.

Passing on the Vigil and the Next Law of Shadows

Throughout the night, watchers take turns pressing their ears to the clay, hearing a name and waking the next person. Listening changes from a private emotion into a communal practice. Finally, Ananya writes “The Law of Shadows,” because after a body has been made, the rights attached to its falling shadow will also become a question. This anticipation of the next title opens a further difficulty rather than presenting an assured resolution.

Critical Section 222 | Original Chapter 121 — The Cage of Caste

Invisible Bars Behind the Body of Justice

Chapter 120 fashioned the clay body of justice; Chapter 121 immediately reveals that the invisible cage of caste remains intact within society. The sequence is artistically significant. Just as justice takes shape, the arrangements that prevent its social enactment come into view. The narrator does not allow the reader a prolonged celebration of the earlier achievement, but shows the bars of an old captivity surrounding the newly formed body.

Constructing the Cage from Conduct Rather than Objects

The bars of this cage are made from descent, gotra, food, cooking, touch, marriage, cremation grounds and the distribution of water. These practices and objects together organise the story's social geography. An iron cage is visible; the social cage remains concealed in daily acts. By unpacking the metaphor through concrete behaviour, the narrator prevents it from becoming only a general image of oppression.

The Elderly Guardian of Genealogies

An elder from a Brahmin family arrives carrying copies of copperplate inscriptions, genealogies and a yellowed manuscript. The smell of old paper, the edges of pages and the man's movements lend the scene a solemn, almost museum-like air. His question, however, aims to limit who has the right to write names. Documentary ornament lends social force to his claim. Ananya makes room for everyone to question the linguistic source of that authority.

The Narrative Entry of Gangesha's Voice

The stump's shadow spreads over the manuscript and an unidentified voice becomes audible. Ba says that Gangesha has arrived. The passage does not claim that a historical person has literally returned to the world outside the novel. Gangesha enters the fictional world as a voice generated by memory. The narrator represents what the characters hear, turning a mythic presence into a scene of shared experience rather than a proposition independently submitted for verification.

The Monument of Scholarship and the Silence Around a Life

Ira's question begins with Gangesha's important text, but Ba's response turns towards the suppressed circumstances of the thinker's life. Two constructions of a person confront each other: official idealisation and

remembrance that includes social discomfort. The critic's concern here is not to measure the actual worth of the text, but to examine what the narrator permits to speak and what silencing becomes part of the plot.

Charmakarni's Incomplete Name and an Imagined Voice

Soil falling through a crack in the stump takes on a shape resembling a footprint or shoe impression. The characters speculate that it belongs to Charmakarni; the supposition is not presented as an unquestionable historical fact. Then a woman's voice brings forward contradictions involving labour, shoes, drums and marriage. Its narrative consequence is to make the invisible woman more than an appendix to a celebrated man: she becomes a presence capable of posing her own questions.

The Product of Labour and the Exclusion of the Body

Charmakarni's imagined voice points out that society uses leather to make shoes and musical instruments while declaring the people who work with that leather untouchable. This contradiction establishes a deep link with Chapter 119's treatment of labour. The product of work is welcome in every household, the worker's body prohibited. The narrative power of this irony lies in its daily occurrence. Caste is not presented in isolation from economic structures.

Writing Names and Exercising Caution About Accusations

The names of Ramanath Jha and Udaychandra Jha "Ashok" appear within the story as occasions for questions. Ananya says that they are writing questions, not accusations. The distinction is indispensable. To treat a memory-related allegation made by a fictional character as an independent historical verdict would be a critical error. Through the controversy, the author illuminates the protection of names, the right to question and the selection of language used for honour. The novel does not, by itself, settle factual disputes outside its text.

Batuknath's Fear for Institutional Authority

Batuknath urges the others to set aside controversies about a thinker's life and treat the great book as an ideal work. He fears less for the book than for the erosion of social authority supported by its veneration. Later he writes a secret letter asking that the caste discussion be restricted. In this sequence the character's old habit of control returns in a new form. The author rejects a simplistic line of development in which a person becomes wholly transformed by making an apology.

A Small Public Experiment in Touch

The same soil from the stump falls on the hands of a leatherworker and a person from a supposedly higher caste. Nobody performs a rite of purification; the clay stains both palms alike. The narrative does not proclaim the complete abolition of caste distinctions. It creates, through a single bodily experience, a small public exception to an established prohibition. The credibility of the scene is strengthened by the modesty of the victory.

The Changing Boundaries of Kitchens and Wells

After the school reaches its decision, some kitchens become more accessible and the spaces around wells open a little further. The narrator does not announce the end of caste through an extraordinary proclamation; instead, change is signalled through behaviour at household thresholds. The spatial scale is small but the consequences for human relationships are considerable. Thresholds, well platforms and kitchens become tests of social focalisation.

The Dust of Questions and the Reversal of Sanctity

White dust from the stump falls on a child's forehead. Ananya rejects the easy reading of it as a religious mark and calls it "the dust of questions." This renaming changes the earlier language of classical prestige. A symbol that could confer authority becomes an instrument of questioning rather than worship. The social meaning of the magical substance is determined by a character's words.

An Uncertain Victory and the Next Tension

The image of a crack in the cage of caste is forceful, but Batuknath's secret letter shows that the machinery of control remains active. This double ending protects the chapter from the sentimentality of complete resolution. A small collective change in practices of touch and covert institutional resistance proceed along the same timeline. The simultaneous opposition sustains the tension necessary for the next movement of the long novel.

Critical Section 223 | Original Chapter 122 — Gangesha's Liberation

The Double Chronology of Individual Memory and the Cage of Caste

Chapter 122 begins immediately after the night of the cage of caste. Its bars do not disappear with the morning; instead, sunlight makes them more distinct. This reversal in the passage of time establishes the chapter's structural premise: the transformation experienced during the nocturnal assembly must confront, the next morning, the continuing force of society's inherited vocabulary. Although "liberation" appears as a dramatic event, the narrative situates it within an unfinished struggle. The chapter therefore resists a simple movement from darkness to an achieved social freedom.

A Child's Question in Search of the Key

Seeing an empty space beneath the preceding page's title, "The Cage of Caste," Ananya asks who holds its key. Ba draws a line in the soil, and the scene of that line being continually erased recurs. The rhythm does not represent a fixed solution; it gives visible form to repeated attempts to frame the question. What propels the action is a child's curiosity, not an explanation already prepared by an authoritative speaker. The line's making and unmaking also keep the question materially present within the setting.

Letters Emerging from the Stump's Black Dust

Black dust rises from within the severed Channa stump and gradually forms dots, lines and, finally, words. The scene builds towards the sign of "evidence" through successive changes of shape. Its dramatic power resides less in the completed word than in the process of its emergence. Questions once put before the assembly now seem to arise from the substance of the earth itself. Yet the narrative's language of nature is a magical action within the fictional world, not an independently established historical demonstration.

The Empty Seat and the Pregnant Woman in the Mirror

A drop of water becomes a tiny mirror, revealing the shadow of an empty seat, an extinguished lamp and a pregnant woman. The account of a birth occurring many years after the father's death also enters the scene in the voice of popular memory. To treat this extraordinary narrative as an authenticated biographical fact would go beyond the text. At the critical level, the unusual birth story exposes the unstable relation among

recollection, impossibility and social silence. The mirror offers an image for interpretation, not a document that settles the past.

The Charmakarni Scene and Many Women's Voices in One

In the mirror, the shadow of a Charmakarni woman is surrounded by scholars, hereditary priests and guardians of names. Meera raises the absence of the woman's actual name. A single caste-designating word breaks apart and becomes a plurality of women's voices. A character can signify collective oppression without thereby recovering the particular personal name that has been withheld from her. Preserving this difference is a central narrative ethic of the chapter: representative significance must not be mistaken for the restoration of an individual's identity.

The Unstable Count of Twelve Thousand Lines

The stump appears to shine with twelve thousand minute lines, drawing on a familiar numerical image of the greatness of a text. Gop attempts to count them, but the lines vanish from memory whenever his gaze comes to rest on them. The magical arrangement casts doubt on the stability of enumeration itself. The value of a work cannot be measured merely by the number of its pages. The narrator turns that claim into a sensory experience, in which attempts at precise calculation repeatedly fail in the presence of a supposedly monumental text.

Writing Honour and Misusing Silence

The story suggests that inconvenient aspects of a thinker's life may be suppressed in the making of an honourable public image. Within this episode, the word "honour" acquires a negative function: it offers selective recollection in place of questions. The author's concern is to uncover the social process of editing concealed within the characters' understanding of commemoration. Claims concerning a historical person that remain disputed must be identified as voices within the novel, not silently converted into verified assertions about a life outside the fictional text.

Satyavrat's Changing Narrative Role

Satyavrat initially restrains Gop's eagerness to open the documents; later, he speaks of the right to determine the language in which questions may be asked. By diminishing the authority attached to his former legal office, he acknowledges the difficulty of listening to others. The internal sequence of these scenes shows that moral change is not achieved through a single sentence of repentance but through repeated practice. Across the novel, his previous delays continue to provide a measure against which his present humility is judged.

Four Stones in Sequence and the Plurality of Memory

At the final evening, four different stones are placed around the stump: one for Gangesha's name, one for the awaited name of the Charmakarni woman, one for the truth of a life that has been cut away, and one for the fire of questioning. This arrangement brings honour and absence into the same space without dissolving one into the other. Rather than constructing one memorial resembling a tomb, the characters attempt to preserve a plurality of questions. The distinct stones prevent a single commemorative form from claiming the entirety of memory.

Information Management by the Opposing Networks

Lau's adviser calls the episode a risk to the heritage project. Broom's network considers classifying it as folklore and excluding it from the official record. Chandrapal imagines making the controversy an attraction for an application. These are three different forms of information control within the narrative. Suppressing the community's question and selling it as content emerge as related expressions of the same desire to govern the terms under which memory circulates. The methods differ, but the governing impulse persists.

The Sound of Questions in Kabaddi

During the night game, the children chant "evidence" alongside "kabaddi." The physical rules of play have changed very little, but crossing the boundary becomes a way to hold open questions concerning names, memory and narrative. Through this recurrence, a traditional children's game becomes a setting for social disagreement about knowledge. The critic's attention must remain on the narrative transformation of play, rather than treating the episode as an independent exposition of a technical concept in logic.

The Incomplete Meaning of "Liberation"

The final voice refuses to recognise someone who fears questions as a rightful authority in matters of justice. This sharp statement changes the title's meaning: "liberation" is not literal release from a visible enclosure but the restoration of a right to ask. Yet the Charmakarni woman's complete name is still unknown, and institutional controls remain in operation. The novel deliberately makes its liberation conditional. This incompletion creates the need for the next chapter, "The Leaf of Tattvachintamani," instead of closing the question prematurely.

Critical Section 224 | Original Chapter 123 — The Leaf of Tattvachintamani

From an Embodied Idea to a Living Leaf

Chapter 122 represented Gangesha's memory as freed by renewed questioning; Chapter 123 turns to the protection of that questioning. In place of a fixed page in a book, a tender green leaf on a new shoot becomes the scene's moving centre. The transformation is fragile: a leaf may dry up, fall, or grow again. A work may possess enduring prestige while its living social meanings still demand repeated rereading. The narrator contrasts the stability of a revered text with the vulnerability and renewal of its public interpretation.

The Sapling's Insufficient Shade and the Future Accepted in Advance

The children sit around a new sapling too small to provide shade. They gather there as though accepting in advance the shade it may offer in the future. This economical scene presents the future not as an accomplished fact but as an awaiting public possibility. The contrast between the defeat of the old felled tree and the new tree's shade, which does not yet exist, thickens the narrative's sense of time. Hope is enacted in the present without being misrepresented as fulfilled.

The Leaf's Invisible Script and Listening as a Mode of Seeing

Aruni brings the new leaf; Gop puts on his spectacles but cannot decipher its lines. Ananya then holds the leaf to her ear. The narrator shifts the sensory centre of perception from eye to ear. The invisible script is not read through the successful recognition of literal letters, but through the act of asking questions. This restrained magical image brings out the limits of different media of expression. Reading becomes an activity of listening rather than simply a demonstration of visual or scholarly mastery.

Four Circles in the Soil: The School as a Stage

The children draw four circles in the soil and bring a different social example into each. The important achievement here is not a technical exposition of logic but the conversion of difficult language into the spatial arrangement of a game. The circles give children a place from which to raise questions of responsibility; they do not themselves issue final judgments on historical disputes. The chapter is structured through questions and answers, not through dependence on an expository treatise. Its argument unfolds as a staged social encounter.

Caste Pride and the Violence That Can Be Seen

In the first circle, a child raises a question about the visibility of caste. Meera replies that the consequences for bodies and the experience of humiliation can be seen, whereas the claim of inherent superiority is a cage constructed by society. The narrator thereby opens the relation between invisible forms of power and palpable suffering. The episode does not attempt the systematic demonstration of an abstract category. It stages a collective discussion whose point of attention is the experience of the person harmed.

The Repeated Disappearance of an Erased Name

At the second circle, Ira returns to the name that has repeatedly been removed from the records. Its recurrence connects this later chapter to the novel's earlier bridge disaster, hospital records, digital fraud, caste registers and tenders for memory. The objects and institutions differ, but "the removal of a name" returns as a narrative action. The critical force of repetition lies in the creation of layered structure: each new record alters how readers understand omissions in the previous ones without resolving them all.

Scriptural Authority and the Children's Debate

In the third circle, a priest's grandson claims supreme authority for a scriptural pronouncement. Meera sits opposite him and recalls the humiliation suffered by a body. The discussion is dramatic because the speakers occupy different social positions and possess different kinds of experience. The narrator also risks reducing one side of the dispute to a figure who is simply left without an answer. In this instance, however, the boy's silence signals the limits of the language of domination rather than the completion of a philosophical proof.

The Vacancy in Charmakarni's Name and the Unresolved Search

In the fourth circle, Ananya asks why the unknown Charmakarni woman's full name has not been found. The narrative has repeatedly protected this vacancy rather than conveniently filling it. Here it is not merely a philosophical example: it makes visible the ethics of deciding whose name is remembered and whose is put aside. The author does not invent a personal name to complete the record. Consequently, the search retains its incompletion and the woman is not made into an entirely knowable figure by the critic's convenience.

Unstable Enumeration and the Vastness of the Text

The new leaves appear to multiply—one, two, fifty—yet counted leaves seem to need counting again. The question of "twelve thousand" is linked

with this unstable spectacle. Number functions here as an image of comparative grandeur, not a literal calculation guaranteed by evidence. Ba places more emphasis on what a question means than on the number of items. The reader's sense of vastness therefore arises from both exaggeration and visual movement, with neither turned into a determinate scholarly measurement.

The Gatekeepers of the Gangesha Study Council

Two scholars arrive from the city and demand a controlled presentation and scientific editing of materials treated as folklore. They carry a camera, permission forms and a specialised vocabulary. Through this collection of objects, institutional expertise acquires visible form in the plot. The narrative does not necessarily reject scholarly study itself. It objects to the tendency to turn that expertise into unilateral ownership over the local community's right to ask questions. The tension is between research as inquiry and research as control of access.

A Fallen Leaf on Paper and a Silent Objection

A new leaf falls without a sound on the scholars' paper. The paper grows damp and the printed lines blur. No outside power delivers a violent verdict in this restrained magical scene. Instead, a natural substance makes a small disturbance in the certainty of the printed page. The meeting of dew on the leaf with ink on paper gives another form to the novel's recurrent images of water and writing. The scene alters the material record without pretending to settle its disputed contents.

Ananya's Final Rule and the Narrative Voice

Ananya places three limits before the assembly: scripture must not stand above a human being; testimony of humiliation must not be denied; and the question of an unnamed woman must not be declared impossible to pursue. The collective response, "present," had hitherto belonged to the ritual of reading names. Here it becomes a shared recognition of the right to question. Through this change, the children's school emerges as a sustained force generating speech and action throughout the long novel, rather than merely a background setting.

An Unnamed Voice and the Undecided Ending

On the last night a voice rises from within the root, but its source cannot be established: it is neither clearly Gangesha, the old ghost, nor one of the children. The possibility that it belongs to the unnamed Charmakarni woman is suggested but never announced as certain. This uncertainty is the narrative's ethical centre. The narrator refuses to confer an effortless complete identity upon someone whose name has not been recovered. The

final question thus makes justice the work of a continuing search, not a conclusion authorised by an unexplained voice.

Inter-Sectional Discussion — From Soil to the Leaf of Questions

Across Chapters 108–123, the narrative moves from matter to voice, from voice to silence, from silence to the body, from the body to labour, and from labour to caste relations. The first eight chapters, concerned with soil, water, fire, air and sky, examine different limits of the social archive. The following eight turn the practical consequences of that archive into questions of unpaid debts to the living, permission to touch, rest for working people and names denied by caste. This movement from remembered objects to relationships among living people binds the two groups into an uninterrupted compositional sequence.

The narrator repeatedly makes small objects the centre of a scene: a wet register, soil among roots, an empty bowl, a wall marked with charcoal, the vacant space of the unnamed Charmakarni woman, a torn shoe, a nail, a wage slip, the clay body of justice, a copperplate, a mirror and a fresh green leaf. These objects do not simply repeat a single meaning. The empty page gives visible form to the protection of silence; the unnamed stone represents the necessity of inquiry; and the clay body of justice makes the public duty to listen visible. Their distinct functions sustain variation across the extended prose narrative.

Ananya, Meera, Devika, Gop, Aruni, Satyavrat, Ba, Surmani Kaki, the wife of Jhagaru Mistri, Bhagelu Paswan and the imagined voice of the Charmakarni woman provide separate centres of perspective. Ananya's questions become rules; Meera's fear discloses the boundaries of privacy; Gop's work with data reveals an incomplete archive; Aruni's memory as an engineer recalls failures in public construction; and Satyavrat's repeated movement towards a seat among others marks his unfinished transition from authority to listening. No single protagonist renders a definitive judgment on the whole narrative.

The silent kabaddi of Chapter 116 and the question-centred kabaddi of Chapters 122–123 display a changing grammar of play. When speech is no longer required, the sounds of feet, soil and clothing can be heard; later, names, questions and responsibility enter the game's enclosed space. This recurrence is not decoration but a narrative procedure for seeking new forms of community. The changing boundaries marked by the throat and the lines in the earth become integral instruments of narrative development.

In Chapters 121–123, Gangesha, caste memory and Tattvachintamani appear through characters, folklore, magical images and the children's school. The discussion reads them as levels of narration within the novel,

not as decisive independent biographical evidence or demonstrations of logical doctrine. The names of Ramanath Jha and Udaychandra Jha "Ashok" likewise occur as part of questions raised inside the story; the passage should not be read as a verified accusation concerning actual history. Its narrative concerns are the selection of memory, the exercise of authority and the public accessibility of questions.

This sequence proclaims no complete victory. The right to silence is recognised, but trade in imitated voices remains possible. Debt is connected to work, but the intrigue surrounding a conditional payment of honour money persists. A code for the body has been framed, yet caste registers are opened. Workers' names are read aloud, but enduring protection for wages remains unresolved. A clay body of justice has been made, but those wishing to sell its replicas remain active. The Charmakarni woman's actual name is still missing. Instead of silently filling these gaps, the text carries the unresolved questions forward as necessities for the next movement of the story.

Critical Section 225 | Original Chapter 124 — The Fire of Evidence

The Transformation of the Symbol from Leaf to Fire

In Chapter 123 the leaf of Tattvachintamani became an invisible script of questions. In the next chapter, the lines on that same leaf rise into the radiance of fire. The scene does more than introduce a new controversy: it transforms an object carried forward from the preceding chapter. Leaf, sunlight, root, smoke and flame form a linked visual sequence in which the centre of authority shifts from a written treatise towards people's right to ask questions. When the leaf's "evidence" becomes "whose evidence?" as soon as someone touches it, the altered writing suggests that meaning is not fixed on paper but made in contact with readers and social circumstances.

The Character of Fire: Disclosure Rather Than Burning

The fire named in the title does not function as an agent of punishment. The original narrative repeatedly says that the leaf does not burn; rather, its letters turn red. When Ba touches the leaf, its smoke is white rather than black. This visual arrangement gives precedence to the light that exposes what has remained unseen, instead of to violent purification. Reversing the traditional destructive image of fire, the narrator constructs a critical scene whose object of fear is not a human being but the convenience of half-remembered history. The characters, however, initially approach the metaphor with strong moral certainty, sometimes compressing the complexity of the opposing position.

Rewriting the Question Through a Child's Perspective

Ananya adds "whose" to "evidence," "justice" and "lineage," turning general nouns into questions. This small grammatical alteration is the chapter's central narrative action: abstract terms are brought back into social relations. The girl's focus is not a neutral, omniscient perspective; her attention remains on a person who has been made invisible. Readers encounter not merely the celebrated scale of an ostensibly great text but the public circumstances in which it is read. The presence of people deprived of the right to question sustains the opening mystery and draws readers into Ananya's still incomplete search.

Gop's Documents and the Cut Edges of Knowledge

Gop Kumar has preserved information on paper. In this chapter he acknowledges that documents do not contain the entirety of a life. The narrative does not take away his earlier technical competence; it adds to his

credibility the ability to revise his understanding. Official archives and oral memory both remain present in the plot, but the narrator emphasises the possibility of lines omitted from a document rather than accepting its apparent completeness. The episode must be read as a fictional critique of the selection of memory, not as an independently proven accusation about external history. The reader does not know what separate records substantiate every element of the folklore recounted.

The Garland of Honour and the Image of a Noose

In Ba's speech, a flower garland acquires the possibility of becoming a noose. A gentle object of cultural recognition turns into a metaphor for coercive control, allowing the story to depict a form of injury to memory without any directly represented bloodshed. Meera's expression "murder in the name of honour" maintains a distinction between killing a body and destroying a memory. The novel's language of accusation is therefore figurative, not a legal report of a proven homicide. Keeping that distinction clear preserves the moral sharpness of the scene without turning suggestions involving real historical individuals into unsupported factual conclusions.

Editorial Shadows and Narrative Allegations

Shadows associated with Ramanath Jha and Udaychandra Jha "Ashok" appear upon the leaf. They do not enter as fully embodied characters but as the hands of readers cutting away lines. Two actions occur together in this performance: the removal of biographical passages and the placing of a garland around scholarly greatness. The dreamlike staging invites reflection on the selection involved in writing literary history, but a shadow is not itself an archival record of an actual editorial act. Its trembling after the girl's counterquestion supplies dramatic decisiveness. This is an uncompromising mode of fictional debate, not a comprehensive, verified account of literary historiography.

The Unnamed Charmakarni Woman: The Weight of the Blank Space

The chapter's most powerful image is the stone upon which people continue searching for the name of the Charmakarni woman. The narrative does not fill it with an invented personal name. The unoccupied space behaves almost like a character in motion: people return to it, change their questions and create expectations about the next event. Besides serving as an image of social exclusion, the missing name produces uncertainty for the reader. Keeping that uncertainty alive is the episode's real compositional accomplishment. An immediate answer would confine a complex history inside an easy resolution and cancel the work the blank space performs.

Water and Soil Answer Back

The water-dweller's voice from the pond, the smell of earth, the warmth of stones and green leaves on the dried stump temper the one-sided severity of the fire scene. The four elements interrupt one another and produce a succession of imagined testimonies in the narrative world. Earlier fears surrounding water burial and crocodiles return in the image of soil free from caste. The narrator develops a bitter irony around the fact that crocodiles do not ask a person's caste. Its force does not lie in attributing moral virtue to wild creatures, but in exposing the inhumanity of hierarchies constructed by human beings.

Satyavrat Changes His Seat

The children ask Satyavrat Mehta to sit among them. For a man who once held judicial office, this is not merely a change of chair: it redistributes control over the narrative encounter. Someone who formerly determined the limits of admissible evidence now listens to and records questions without imposing that authority in advance. His trembling hand signifies a process of reform, not complete moral liberation. Ananya's exposure of the inadequacy of legal language offers a transition in which institutions do not become unnecessary; instead, they incur an obligation to examine their own procedures.

The Mediation of Oral Debate

The exchanges involving Ba, Ira, Meera, Gop, Satyavrat and the children move broadly towards a common conclusion, but each speaker occupies a separate social position. Ba contributes knowledge grounded in bodily experience; Ira raises questions about history; Meera speaks from women's experience; Gop doubts the sufficiency of information; and Satyavrat brings a memory shaped by law. Together these voices form a communal interpretation. Yet the opposing characters' arguments are frequently silenced almost immediately. As a result, the polyphonic structure contains a powerful attraction towards consensus, and this tendency itself requires critical assessment.

Folk Song and the Difference in Narrative Time

An opening song in the Jhijhiya-Mangal rhythm, with lamps being circled, proposes a meaning that the later prose fills with specific absences of names and scenes of editorial shadows. The folk song promises light everywhere; the principal narrative raises uncomfortable questions concerning particular people. Readers first receive the metaphor of fire and gradually encounter its social consequences. These two modes of narration, song and prose, do not coincide perfectly. Against the song's assurance, the uncertainty surrounding an excised life persists to the last moment.

The Next Chapter's Promised Title and the Deviation

At the end, Ananya writes the title "The Charmakarni Woman's Name." A reader would naturally expect the following chapter to take up a direct search for that name. But Chapter 125 is instead called "The Rice of Judgment" and turns towards the field. In compositional terms this deviation might be understood as a method of carrying a question of memory into living labour and transplantation. It is also a discernible textual inconsistency or a promise left in suspension. The criticism does not claim that one explanation alone represents the author's intention. This openness keeps the actual difficulty of the chapter sequence visible.

Conclusion: The Vacancy Remaining After the Light

The chapter's ultimate significance does not gather in a definition from a theory of justice, but in the empty space remaining within the circle of fire. When the leaf, shadow, flower, stone and girl's register all participate in searching for one woman's name, the critical focus becomes the question of whose story was written and whose was cut away. Fire offers no answer; it reveals why the search is necessary. In this sense, the chapter is less a narrative of finding the answer than of transmitting and postponing the question. Its unresolved tension enters the ensuing rice sequence through a different set of objects.

Critical Section 226 | Original Chapter 125 — The Rice of Judgment

The Narrative Movement from Ash to Field

After the fire of evidence in the preceding chapter, the cooled ash is taken directly into a field. This change moves the novel from abstract dispute to the scene of agricultural labour. The author does not invent an unrelated cause for a fresh event; the ash itself provides a material bridge between two scenes. Aruni observes its varied colours, Ba takes out the rice seed, and the children walk a path restricted by caste. Transformation of a recurring symbol becomes the principal narrative motor. The reader awaits the outcome of an experiment: can justice move from a written judgment to the act of sowing?

The Search for Charmakarni Turns Towards Agriculture

Chapter 124 ended with an announcement that the missing name would be sought directly, but Chapter 125 offers no immediate answer. Instead the narrative enters the field of a family historically excluded through its association with leatherwork. The search has not been abandoned; its form has altered. In place of an individual's missing historical identity, labour, land and the public structures of untouchability come forward. Nevertheless, the altered title also frustrates the reader's expectation. A clearer temporal indication or acknowledgement that the search had been deferred could have made the sequential transition less abrupt.

A Change of Setting and a Reorganisation of Perspective

The community moves from the enclosure around the stump to the embankment of a field, changing the spatial centre of the fictional world. A caste problem seen by the roots is now experienced through land ownership and agricultural work. The elderly woman of a leatherworking family owns her place; she is not presented only as a victim, but as an active character who directs the use of the plough and accepts the seed. From this perspective, land becomes a new participant in the story rather than an object entered into an archive. A living economic space opens beyond the memory of the Channa stump.

The Confluence of Seed, Ash and Transplanting

Rice seed represents future possibility, ash is the surviving substance of earlier violence, and water makes transformation possible. All three enter the work of planting together. In one scene, the narrator brings together three temporal layers: the past, the labour of the present and the food that may be produced in the future. This density of symbolism is a considerable

achievement of the chapter. Yet the ash seems to derive from several different kinds of earlier image; there is no need to identify it as literal laboratory ash. The story employs it as an imaginative substance shaped by memory.

Taking Turns with the Plough and Expanding Agency

The old Charmakarni woman takes the first furrow, Aruni the second, Meera the third, Satyavrat the fourth and Ananya the fifth. In this succession, the old vertical order of social prestige becomes a sequence of shared work. Justice is no longer represented only by those who give speeches but by people turning the earth with their own hands. Taking turns becomes a subtle compositional device: each new pair of hands questions a boundary of former social distance. A single night of planting cannot prove that lasting social equality has been achieved, but it supplies a visible rehearsal of change.

The Kabaddi Line and the Reversed Meaning of a Field Boundary

An old field boundary continues to mark caste separation; the children turn the crossing of that central line into a game. Kabaddi does not function here simply as entertainment. It reuses an inherited structure of prohibition. A line that once prevented movement becomes the very place where a transition occurs in the narrative. Through this alteration, the earlier game of ghostly kabaddi connects with the present agricultural action. Merely erasing the line would not suffice: the courage required to cross it socially gives the game its fuller meaning.

Bringing Satyavrat's Language of Judgment Down to Earth

Satyavrat experiences the difference between a judicial ruling and the judgment that takes shape in a field. His earlier training concerned written legal decisions; here, crops, the division of produce and eating together offer possible consequences of a decision. His uncertainty reveals a changing character, although the narrator does not suddenly pronounce him a farmer. Touching the soil quietly, taking up seed and acknowledging his relationship to the field mark practical development rather than mere instruction in morality. The chapter thereby turns from earlier testimonies towards the conditions of a living livelihood.

The Water-Dweller's Glimmer and an Uncertain Encounter

A glimmer appears in the water within the field. Whether this is the presence of the water-dweller or simply the play of light remains undecided even in the narrator's account. Magical realism enters the scene through precisely this uncertainty. People connect the shimmer with the water-dweller's earlier testimony, but no one gives a final verdict. Such

controlled indeterminacy places the reader's gaze between the happening and the characters' experience of it. The symbol's significance depends not on physical verification but on how the gathered people respond to what they see.

The Narrative Status of "Joint Evidence"

The expression "joint evidence" arises among the stories of the old Charmakarni woman, Gangesha and the unnamed woman. Rather than reaching a technical conclusion through scriptural debate, the narrative uses the phrase as a linguistic attempt to bring more than one life into view together. Where the public account of a distinguished life has left another life half-recognised, showing their intertwined relation becomes an ethical demand. The criticism does not treat the phrase as the establishment of a proposition in formal logic. It is the speech of particular characters and an expression of the novel's politics of memory.

Scholars' Shadows and Indirect Opposition

The names of Ramanath Jha and Udaychandra Jha "Ashok" arise once more in connection with questions. Their recurrence links the reader with the controversy of the previous chapters. Here the means of answering the problem is not a lawsuit but the moral pressure of work in a field. The narrative does not directly reconstruct the arguments made by those external individuals. Their repeated names therefore function as literary shadows, not as an independent historical judgment. Recognising the distinction allows attention to remain on the social relationships being formed around agricultural labour.

From Screen to Unappropriated Soil: The Discipline of Looking

Devika takes out a device to photograph the planting and then puts it away. The impulse to convert the event immediately into digital heritage is interrupted. Chandrapal's application and Lau's phrase "field asset" are set against the sensation of a field that cannot simply be appropriated by an image. The existence of a device is not itself the wrong; the wrong lies in trying to compress an emerging struggle into profitable visual content. The author makes this judgment visible through the character's decision rather than through proclamation alone.

Time Left Open Between Planting and Harvest

The plough continues moving until evening, and at night the stars shine like seeds. Ananya explicitly says that the ending of the rice of judgment will be known at harvest. Her words establish an expectation of future time within the fiction. Although the duration of an agricultural cycle is suggested, ripe ears of grain appear immediately in the following chapter,

an inconsistency that the subsequent reading must confront. The present chapter depicts only the completion of planting: the actual interval before fruition is neither marked as a leap in time nor named as a dream. Its rhythm may be poetic, but its chronology remains uncertain.

Conclusion: The Relocation of the Written Judgment

The achievement of "The Rice of Judgment" lies not in announcing a conclusion but in materially relocating agency. Fire becomes ash; ash enters the field with seed; hands once prohibited by social boundaries take hold of the plough. This progression creates an outline of change within the story. But the unnamed Charmakarni woman's name remains unfound, caste boundaries have not been demonstrably destroyed, and no crop has yet grown. By attending to these unfinished conditions instead of insisting on completion, the chapter makes itself a necessary bridge to the coming question of justice in food.

Critical Section 227 | Original Chapter 126 — The Justice of Food

Beginning with the Ear of Grain: An Abrupt Change of Time

After the evening-and-night planting in “The Rice of Judgment,” “The Justice of Food” opens with ears of rice bending in the morning. In an ordinary agricultural cycle, months separate sowing or transplanting from harvest; the novel does not account explicitly for this interval. One possible reading takes the rice as an emblem of justice and sees the agricultural cycle compressed into a poetic instant. Another regards the passage as an inconsistency in the editing of narrative time. Criticism ought to preserve both possibilities, since the text supplies neither an explicit dream framework nor a stated extended lapse of time.

Shifting the Narrative Axis from Memory of the Dead to Living Stomachs

In this chapter on grain, the children move from the circle of names inscribed on stones to the kernels of the field. The long sequence of recording the dead now becomes a political and ethical struggle over living people's right to food. The declaration that every scripture and ritual remains incomplete before a hungry stomach expresses the characters' moral position; its narrative significance is that justice is measured against a material outcome. The earlier flood, bridge disaster and digital fraud return to memory through the scarcity of food, thickening the chain of interconnected social events.

Compassion and Entitlement as Contrasting Terms in Dialogue

Ba describes compassion as rice thrown down from above and a rightful share as rice eaten while sitting together. The comparison produces an immediate image of the social row and the equal height of bodies. In charitable giving, the donor stands above and the hungry receiver below; in sharing, both occupy the same level. The narrator makes an abstract dispute over food distribution accessible to the reader's imagination. Whatever position the reader may hold, the distinction in words makes the postures of giver and recipient instantly visible.

From Empty Bowls to a Public Register of Hunger

Women arrive carrying weights and measures, winnowing trays, cooking pots and empty bowls. Alongside the register of names, the absence of any record of hunger becomes a new ethical deficiency. Familiar household objects turn into instruments of social inquiry. Ananya does not compile a

list of donors; she opens a way to hear accounts of deprivation and undernourishment. The earlier principle of consent in the practice of listening to silence is applied to a new subject: the right to food concerns dignity, not the public display of shame.

The People's Memory Trust's Grain Fund: Unequal Aims in the Same Vocabulary

A messenger from Hariharan proposes a grain fund under which donors' names would appear on an inscribed plaque. Its language promises assistance, but behind it lies the possibility of converting remembrance into promotional honour. The manoeuvre structurally resembles earlier proposals involving tenders, an app and a memorial. Again and again, the expression "people's memory" becomes a mask for offers of profit. Through this recurrence, the narrator cultivates an alert reader capable of reading the long provisions of attractive paperwork and recognising the relations of power concealed within them.

The Digital Gateway and the Exclusion of Hunger

Chandrapal's proposed digital grain pass collects facial images, fingerprints, family lists and donors' advertisements. The previous episode of fraud through screens renders the new scheme suspect. The reader does not yet possess a complete prosecutorial case; rather, suspicion arises from the convergence of an established character's methods and a new mechanism of control. The author exposes the tension between distribution founded on an equal claim against hunger and a gateway conditioned on the collection of personal data. The narrative conflict is not a general hostility to technology but the conditions imposed on access to a right.

Lau's Foreign Seed and the Sign of Another Bargain

Lau Kin-Hung's offer of high-yield seed links the discussion of agricultural justice to the market associated earlier with the nameless planet and New Horizon. Aruni asks about the seed's memory; the consultant's commercial language cannot answer a question about the field's relationships. This episode provides no extended scientific assessment of imported seed. Instead, the plot uses it as a possible metaphor for corporate control. Commentary must therefore remain grounded in the literary implications, not offer a definitive judgment on the safety or value of actual crop varieties.

The Collective Grain Store: From Object to Institution

The women decide to establish a shared grain store. For the first time, the vigilance over names acquires the shape of a lasting material arrangement:

grain must be stored, hunger reported, and distribution accounted for. Unlike the emblematic sites of memory, the store aspires to be an institution of daily use. Yet its financial sustainability, rules of access and mechanisms of accountability remain unsettled. The narrator shows not a grand opening ceremony but a small first handful of donated grain, making the institution feel newborn and vulnerable.

The Question of Food at the Threshold of Caste

Elderly pandits feel uneasy about storing the grain of different households in a single granary. In this scene, the boundaries of ritual purity are tested through shared hearths and food. A social narrative that had already established equality in the naming of the dead encounters fresh resistance at mealtime. The particular point of resistance is subtle: quite apart from the method of ration distribution, whose household touch will be judged acceptable in shared food? The difference between declarations of equality and the conduct of bodies advances the narrative.

Entitlement Enters the Language of Kabaddi

On a line drawn with rice leaves, the children play kabaddi while chanting, "Not hunger, but our share." The game had previously signified the defence of names; here its meaning shifts towards economic distribution. The rhythm of the words follows the breath of the players, turning instruction into bodily practice rather than a command. But crossing a boundary traced in the earth is easy in a game; ensuring the rightful share of actual hungry families is harder. The following chapter will repeatedly expose this difference.

A Handful of Gifts and Symbolic Equality

Ujjwal's mother, a labourer's son, a widow and others place small offerings of grain in the communal store. Rather than emphasising the size of the quantities, the narrator gives weight to each contributor's social history. Even half a bowl of flattened rice becomes a narrative of collective responsibility. Yet the scene risks imposing an obligation to glorify donors, particularly when those who are themselves poor contribute from their scarcity. Criticism must ask whether the protected right to receive a share is secured alongside the equal right to give one.

The Unfinished Line and the Expectation of Morning

At the chapter's close, the empty plate, communal store and question of grain have not produced a complete solution. The characters recognise the need to listen to the next story of hunger. The title "The Justice of Food" makes an expansive social promise but does not immediately demonstrate a fully functioning system of distribution. This opening allows Chapter

127, “Naming Hunger,” to follow naturally: gathering food is insufficient without the right of hungry people to be heard. The narrative's strength lies in acknowledging this deferred outcome.

Final Assessment: The Gap Between Symbol and Institution

The rapid movement from transplanted rice to the ear, from the ear to food, and from food to the granary gives the narrative a flash of momentum, but it compresses agricultural time and the protracted labour of organising distribution. The new collective institution is encouraging; questions persist about its supplies, recurring work, the durability of stored grain and family autonomy. Recognising these incompletions, readers can approach the ensuing register of hunger not as another celebration but as a human test of the institution.

Critical Section 228 | Original Chapter 127 — Naming Hunger

The Narrative Sound of an Empty Plate

After the beginning of grain collection in Chapter 126, the morning of Chapter 127 begins with an empty plate. The metal vessel beside the filled granary becomes a direct question. The author does not declare the plate a speaking character; rather, he conveys the weighty sound of its emptiness. This reversal of ordinary perception matters narratologically: an object holding nothing bears the greatest burden of narrative meaning. The earlier figure of the memorial stone returns in an everyday vessel for food, making the present deprivation of living people visible.

The Inequality Between the Names of the Dead and Living Hunger

The narrator states plainly that recording the names of the dead is difficult, but recording the names of the living who are hungry is harder. A dead person does not immediately object in public; a hungry living person brings shame, family ties, reputation and vulnerability into the encounter. Consequently, the rights of characters become questions of narrative technique itself: whose name may be disclosed, whose privacy must be guarded, and whose experience should be heard in their own words? Merely repeating the old method of reciting names would be inappropriate here, and the story changes its rules.

“The Hearth's Fast”: A Metaphor for Shame

The first woman says that the fragrance of cooking rice has been absent for three days, although she has told her child that the hearth is observing a fast. This brief exchange reveals hunger's social discomfort together with a mother's effort to protect her child. Rather than directly announcing the truth, the metaphor used to hide domestic shame strikes the reader more sharply. Ananya makes “the hearth's fast” one of hunger's names. This act of renaming attempts to give a hard reality public meaning without turning deprivation into a spectacle.

The Herdsman and Intergenerational Memory

An elderly herdsman, the second witness, keeps fodder for his cattle while drinking water himself and going to sleep hungry. His reluctance to sell the animals cannot be reduced to market calculation: he is trying to preserve an obligation bound to his father's memory. The narrator presents hunger not simply as insufficient income today but as a conflict between inherited memory and the available economic choices. This minor

narrative strand binds the main novel's remembrance of the dead to the double burden of present subsistence.

"Holiday Hunger": A Reversed View of School Time

A young boy describes the midday meal at school as a means of survival, and his stomach on holidays as an empty playground. What others experience as a joyful holiday becomes, in his account, a time of danger. This inversion exposes dependence on an institution's provision of food. The prose does not seek the boy's financial statistics; it shows his experience of time. Time itself is felt differently according to class, and a small image discloses the depth of social inequality without delivering a speech.

A Stomach Restrained by Fear of Lineage

An elderly woman from a household proud of its high caste refuses grain from another home even while hungry. An external social rule prevails over the body's living need. Ba offers her water first. The gesture matters because food is not forced on someone in the name of respect. The narrator portrays the social fence as fear implanted within the person it injures. A single declaration against caste cannot make meals genuinely shared; experience must change continually.

The Many Miniature Narratives Within the Register

Expressions such as "rice instead of medicine," "salt on credit," "holiday hunger," and "earnings in the city, stomachs in the village" open doors to self-contained miniature stories. Whole lives are not narrated, yet each phrase suggests a different social cause behind a name. In this sense the list is more than a number: it is a dense compression of narratives. Still, when too many phrases accumulate together, individual distinctions can be lost. The first three or four living testimonies counteract that danger.

Devika's Question: From Recording to Feeding

Devika asks directly: "We have written down the names, but when will people eat?" Her question marks the chapter's decisive turn. The narrative requires action lest the school's collection of memories be satisfied with ceremony alone. The distance between listening and feeding becomes another figure for the delay between legal proceedings and judgment. One character's speech pushes the story out of a self-admiring ritual and towards a useful cooking fire.

The Experiment of Removing Donors' Names

A rule is proposed that contributors to the communal store will not have their names displayed on a public plaque of honour. A merchant gives five sacks and requests recognition, but Ananya responds, "The plaque will

belong to hunger," reversing the order of priority. Attention shifts from the donor's prestige to the recipient's entitlement to food. Yet declining public displays of donors' names is not the same as abandoning transparent internal accounts. The narrative does not fully develop this administrative distinction, though it matters for the future credibility of the institution.

The Time and Smell of a Communal Kitchen

The hearth is lit in the evening; the smell of earth long left cold mingles with steam from the first rice. Sensory detail places the reader inside immediate action. What had been an abstract declaration about a plate becomes the work of hands: sorting greens, washing grain and bringing water. The kitchen is situated a little distance from the stone circle of names, so the arrangement of space itself discloses the gap between worship and practical use.

The Foreshadowing of a Single Grain Left Behind

After the communal meal, one grain is deliberately left on an empty plate. The narrative makes this small mark a reminder that no complete solution should be proclaimed. The grain moves from the centre of the plate and comes to rest towards the north, where the old well stands. This almost magical movement gives the following chapter, "Naming Thirst," its geographical direction. The first meal does answer hunger in one immediate sense, but the persistence of a separate crisis of water creates fresh tension in the chain of chapters.

The Unfinished Kitchen and the Question of Permanence

The first communal kitchen appears successful, but the grain store is not yet permanent, the register remains incomplete, and the causes of poverty are intact. The author acknowledges these limitations at the end. The acknowledgement restrains the narrative's celebration and points it towards long-term responsibility. Writing down hunger's names is necessary; regular food, secure work, fairly distributed water and dignified livelihoods for the people named remain tasks for the story to pursue.

Conclusion: Putting the Ritual of Names to a Practical Test

Rather than adding a wholly new social problem, Chapter 127 tests the established practice of guarding names against living hunger. Four principles converge in the scenes of food: the right to remain silent, the protection of dignity, the reconstruction of names, and collective labour. Through individual testimony, the narrator shows the reader the intricacy of human relationships. The effect does not remain a mere sermon, because the woman's hearth, the boy's holidays and the elderly woman's

fear of caste are concrete circumstances. The problem of thirst that follows extends this unresolved reality naturally.

Critical Section 229 | Original Chapter 128 — Naming Thirst

From the Grain of Hunger to the Well: A Change of Scene

The one grain left behind in the preceding chapter comes to rest towards the north, and in this chapter the villagers go towards a dry well. This small marvel selects the narrative's next location. After the emptiness of a plate comes the emptiness of a well: two recurrent shapes of absence reveal hunger and thirst as separate conditions but related experiences of social exclusion. At no point does the plot proclaim one crisis wholly over; the earlier object itself points towards the next emerging obstacle. The grain's movement, rather than a young girl's speech, provides the link between episodes.

Caste History Written on the Well's Body

The old well is not merely a source of water; it is a geography of access barred by caste. An elderly woman recounts how her mother was prevented from drawing water and her water pot was broken. A young man remembers the separate drinking vessel assigned to his grandfather. The two strands belong to different moments but converge at the same site, making generations of prohibition visible. In contrast to a written genealogy, the narrator makes the well's landing an archive of history endured by bodies. Repeated space allows the reader to feel the length of time.

The Breaking of the Water Pot and the Invisibility of Names

The smashing of the elderly woman's mother's water pot is not presented as a spectacular public punishment but as an everyday act of humiliation. To destroy the vessel needed to quench thirst is to deprive a person of the possibility of dignity. This tangible detail shows the reader an unequal distribution of water beneath the village's apparent sameness. Likewise, the grandfather's separate vessel bears not his name but a caste mark, replacing individual identity with collective humiliation. The children now wish to rewrite the meanings of water vessels as they had rewritten those of the stones bearing names.

Two Opposite Routes to the Same Water

On the nameless planet of the dream, water was allocated by numbers; on Earth, caste bars people from it. Ira connects these scenes. The narrator sees not merely a contrast between a glasslike future and an earthen present but a shared structure of control. The local forerunner of the abstract number on the dream planet is the separate drinking vessel at the well. Thus the

earlier dream episode frames the interpretation of a new realistic scene. To read it as a report of an actual planetary voyage would confuse the novel's inner and outer story worlds.

The Sound of an Empty Cup and a Collective Rhythm

An empty metal cup is struck after each testimony in the recitation of names. The same action yields many tones: a gentle tap and a forceful ring are described differently. Through this acoustic repetition, the story makes silent thirst something publicly audible. The imagined heavy sound of the empty plate now becomes an actual metallic instrument. No single hero controls this trust of voices; after each account, another person raises the shared sound.

The Surface of Donated Water and the Uncertainty of Distribution

Chandrapal's app displays a campaign of "water donations in the name of names." Yet it provides no answers about who will receive water, which well will be repaired or who will gain access. The narrative links this informational gap to earlier patterns of financial wrongdoing. A donation of water can appear on a screen; restoring an actual muddy well requires labour. The contrast deepens the recurring critique of digital mediation: the problem is not the existence of screens but the attempt to sell the feeling attached to names in place of genuine water distribution.

Lau's Water Report and the Market's Journey Inward

In Lau Kin-Hung's closed room, the phrase "long-term water supply rights" flashes and turns into the question, "Whose thirst will be sold?" The narrator crosses, in a moment, the distance between the village well and international commercial documentation. Letters changing on a screen within Lau's private field of vision suggest an imaginative movement of inner consciousness, not a comprehensive description of completed economic transactions. A reading mindful of that limit preserves the story's credibility.

Labour as Protagonist: The Work of Cleaning the Well

The narrative does more than debate. By evening the brush around the well has been cleared, and bucket after bucket of water has been drawn out. After the muddy water come comparatively clear streams and the smell of old stone. The count of ten, twenty and thirty buckets embodies time as the rhythm of manual labour. The first bucket is lowered by the elderly woman whose mother was once denied water. Through this reversal of agency, the descendants of those injured by history begin to exercise a new right within the scene.

Water's Cleanliness and Casteless Access: Two Distinct Questions

Muddy water comes out of the well, and the children celebrate as it gradually grows clearer. Yet two questions must remain separate for the reader: whether the water is physically safe to drink, and whether everyone enjoys equal social access to it. Cleaning is made visible, but the story does not detail a real test of drinking-water safety or a maintenance system. Criticism must not silently fill that uncertainty with a declaration of success. The value of the vigil over thirst lies in beginning to remove humiliation at the point of access, not in proving a complete outcome in water management.

A Shared Palmful and the New Arrangement of Ritual

At the communal water ceremony that night, each person takes a palmful from the bucket, speaks their name and acknowledges a shared thirst. No raised throne, priestly order or incantation governs the occasion. Collective repetition resembles ritual, but social participation has become its centre. Nevertheless, the story does not establish whether one evening's performance has ended the old prohibition at every household water pot. The scene is best read, with that doubt intact, as the beginning of a new practice.

The Mythic Water-Dweller and the Breathing Well

Cool air rises from the well as it clears, and people say, "The well has breathed." Personification connects the chapter with the novel's earlier magical-realist episodes about water. The people's expression does not conclusively distinguish an actual current of air from an imagined living well. This uncertainty carries the joy of water's return. The reader need not verify the physical existence of the mythic water-dweller in order to understand the meaning of the collective experience.

The Failure of Raghav's Control of Information

Raghav recognises the water scene's "emotional power" and considers ways of controlling it, but his message will not send. On his screen the ring of the empty cup returns like a sign. In this image a sound created publicly by the community interrupts the language of secret digital communication. This is not the complete destruction of the criminal network, however, but a momentary disruption within the story. The network remains a potential force, and the right to water still needs sustained protection.

A Sensory Bridge to the Coming Episode of Salt

The account of thirst progresses beyond sight and hearing towards taste. The muddy water, the old odour of the well and the touch of water in a cupped hand all engage the body. At the chapter's end, references to river,

pond, water pot, cloud and tears broaden thirst beyond physical water into an embodied experience. The connection to tears supplies the necessary bridge to the next dialogue about salt. Chapter 129 thus enters the sequence not as a diversion but as the gradual introduction of taste and labour.

Critical Section 230 | Original Chapter 129 — The Oath of Salt

From Naming to Taste: A Transition in the Mode of Witness

After food and thirst, the novel places salt at the centre. The substance is minute, but its associations expand through a mother's milk, a labourer's sweat, a woman's tears and the final moisture of a dead body. Through these multiple connections, a small article of taste becomes an image of an entire social memory. The reader encounters salt not merely as a substance of nutritional science but as the meeting point of earlier narratives of work, loss and sharing. The central narrative movement consists in drawing together distinct lines of life around a grain of salt.

No Sea in Mithila: A Geographical Irony

The narrator says that Mithila has no sea, but every body contains salt. The contrast between geographical absence and bodily presence directs the reader's attention away from territorial boundaries towards a common human experience. The claim that grains of salt are materially alike turns into a question about the distinctions between ritually pure and impure touch. The narrative's irony lies in the way one and the same substance of taste appears to acquire a different “caste” at the moment of social contact.

Salt from Ujjwal's Home and Private Grief

Devika brings salt from an old container in Ujjwal's house; his mother trembles when she sees the familiar vessel again. This slight gesture binds an expansive communal chapter to personal grief. If salt served only as a slogan of collective equality, the specificity of a character's pain would disappear. The instant in which the mother recognises the container makes an ordinary household object a keeper of bereavement's time. Even after entering the collective oath, this particular object from the old home does not lose its private weight.

Salt Without Caste and the Challenge to Purity

Meera does not arrange the bowls according to caste. The narrative gains its rhythm from this modest defiance of customary order: the hand of a leatherworking woman, a Brahmin's plate, a labourer's sweat and a woman's tears enter into relation through the same taste. Caste difference is shown not as a quality of salt but as a social decision about its distribution. Children touch the salt and say that it tastes the same. This embodied instant becomes an experience within the narrative rather than another speech about equality.

The Dalit Elderly Woman's Double Injustice

An elderly Dalit woman says that people would eat food cooked by her hands but would not drink water in her house. The narrator exposes the stark contradiction between using her food and rejecting contact with her humanity. Within the story, this sentence is a sharp personal testimony, and behind it falls the long shadow of the episode concerning the Charmakarni woman. The author reveals the contradiction not through a scholastic analysis of caste doctrines but through everyday bodily practices. Its force comes from this concreteness.

The Interaction of Voices in Making an Oath

The women compose a simple oath of their own: they will not forget the labour contained in the salt they eat, and they will honour tears. Its cadence differs from that of an oath in court. Satyavrat observes that formal truth-telling has here become a responsibility of lived conduct. The narrator changes the language of the oath from an empty declaration into a way of remembering attached to taste in the body. How the oath will affect sustained family behaviour, however, is left for later chapters to describe.

The Commercial Appropriation of "Memory Salt"

Merchants propose selling "Garh Narikel Memory Salt" in packaging bearing an image of the Channa stump. An earlier heritage project assumes the form of another product. First there was the collection of the dead's voices, then tickets for the spectacle of memory, and now packets of taste. The market repeatedly attempts to bring new domains of sensory experience under its control. The author recurs to the same method of exploitation while changing the objects involved, and thereby keeps the underlying conflict alive.

Raghav's Message and the Invisible Intermediary

Behind the merchants stands a clandestine message from Raghav advising that memory be turned into consumption. The wrongdoer is not present openly on the stage but enters through an invisible line of communication. The reader sees the object and hears the instruction behind it from a separate source. This two-tier distribution of information sustains the narrative's conspiratorial covering. Even so, the merchants' entire financial plan is not explained. Their role in the present scene is to embody the language of profit.

A Name Spoken Whenever Salt Is Placed in a Home

After the shared oath, people begin uttering a name as they prepare meals at home. The public ceremony moves into private kitchens; this

movement is the episode's most consequential effect. Collective words once spoken near the severed tree live again in the ordinary act of serving food. If speaking names becomes a community habit, remembrance need no longer depend solely upon institutional plaques. Yet the narrator does not assert that this change has become complete and permanent in every household; the account chiefly depicts the events of the present evening.

New Horizon's Taste-Controlled Nutrition

The plans of the distant project show measurements of food, water, salt and taste. The bright glass environment of the dream of leaving Earth now enters into the regulation of meals. Controlled nutrition replaces both social memory and the experience of sharing taste. Comparing the dream sequence with the earthly meal sequence extends the story's emotional reach: on one side stands efficient nourishment without memory, offered in the name of comfort; on the other stands taste together with difficult social relationships.

Salt and the Team Called “Nameless” in Kabaddi

The children form two teams, “Salt” and “Nameless.” At the moment a player touches an opponent, salt's name is joined to the question of memory. This is a new sensory version of the earlier rules for guarding names. The markings of the game expose caste's illusion about human touch. If both teams shed the same sweat on the same ground, the likeness of taste finds expression in the story's bodily language. The image matters for its visual force, not because it fully resolves a social equation.

The Fineness of Salt and the Limits of Representation

Several exchanges make the shared taste of salt and tears an argument for human equality. The image has great ethical force, but similarity in bodily chemistry cannot by itself demonstrate the collapse of caste institutions. The novel creates an affecting literary metaphor, not an empirically proved sociological proposition. Recognising this limit, criticism understands the oath of salt as one element in a lasting practice of labour and eating together. The successful metaphor grows more meaningful when subsequent conduct gives it substance.

Conclusion: History Preserved Within Taste

The oath's final words suggest that salt reminds people through its own taste. In this compositional movement, the narrative uses something as minute as a seed to hold a whole social history in a tiny grain. Personal bereavement, caste humiliation, workers' sweat, the market's catalogue of products and the dream of regulated eating converge within one chapter. “Justice” in relation to taste then becomes the title of the next chapter:

after an oath to remember, the actual practice of sharing food is still to come.

Critical Section 231 | Original Chapter 130 — The Justice of Taste

Justice on the Tongue: A Sensory Narrative Technique

Taste is the chief medium of thought in this chapter. Instead of earlier objects such as the court, register, stone and soil, the tongue, smell, hearth and mouthful of rice carry the scenes forward. The narrator leads the reader from the embodied sensation of eating to the question of social equality. For that reason, the chapter is not simply a description of food; it makes memory and justice into narrative experiences through eating. Though taste is felt within an individual, it remains regulated by social prohibitions.

Preparing the Common Meal and the Village's Many-Voiced Labour

Devika sorts greens, Meera washes rice, Saumya lays out leaves, and Ira explains to a child the relationship between sitting in a row to eat and memory. By assigning each character a distinct task, the author builds a collective scene. The women of the village are the principal workers in this division of labour, but the same scene raises a question: has the burden of cooking once again fallen disproportionately on women's shoulders? The detail of the work shows the real texture of everyday life. A reading that sees only a slogan of equality will miss the inequality within the labour that produces the meal.

An Elder's “Propriety” and Ba's Plate Set Before Him

An elder opposes the common dining row by invoking the proprieties of society. Ba places a plate before him and returns the question. Through this dramatic device, the argument takes place before a material object: the reader sees language struggling against the body's need to eat. The elder's discomfort carries forward the previous image of the cage of caste. Yet communal opposition is not represented as disappearing instantly in this episode. The following chapter on the shared plate will reopen the fear that remains unresolved.

The Group Seeking to Turn Remembrance into Packaged Food

Agents of the heritage project arrive with brightly coloured packets of “Memory Salt,” “Water-Burial Greens” and “Ghost-Kabaddi Flattened Rice.” These products turn earlier folktales, mourning and play into objects for consumption. The author sets the spectacle of the packets against the real labour of preparing greens. Ananya asks whose hunger, whose sweat and whose story of salt are contained in that plastic wrapper.

Her repeated question opens the distance between the market's naming practices and the community's lived experience.

One Mouthful, One Name: The Rhythm of Narrative Structure

As the meal begins, a name of someone dead or excluded is spoken before each mouthful. The register of names is reborn in the rhythm of the tongue. Ujjwal, unnamed workers, bodies drowned in the water-burial disaster and the Charmakarni woman become present at an ordinary meal. The practice gives readers an audible recurrence of the long sequence of names, but its centre has shifted to the activity of nourishing living bodies. The past enters the present act of eating.

Women Who Serve First and Eat Last

Meera notices that many women serve everyone else first and eat whatever remains at the end. Devika writes that justice in taste is incomplete without justice in serving. This small observation moves the narrative's ethical test from the public dining row to domestic labour. Unequal eating order for women within a household can coexist with a public movement against caste. This is a particular achievement of the chapter: the narrative itself recognises a new inequality inside the festival of communal eating.

Satyavrat Sitting at the Back: Humility and Delay

Satyavrat Mehta sits towards the back of the dining row and speaks of honouring the cooks and those formerly excluded. Repeatedly taking a seat at the back has become a sign of the character's transformation. Yet formal humility alone cannot redress the procedural wrongs of the past. The narrator connects his earlier testimony with a new practice of eating, so that the change in someone who has acknowledged his faults becomes visible as repeated conduct. It is not declared an accomplished liberation.

The Limits of Ira's Letter to Children Overseas

Ira considers writing to children abroad about the village meal. Through her, the author questions the difficulty of viewing local taste from a distance. A cookbook or cultural festival cannot convey the full meaning of "Mithila's taste" if the hands once excluded from cooking and the struggle to eat together are left out. The pause of Ira's pen is significant: the character experiences the limits of cultural translation. Her silence does not signify acquiescence, but an awareness that a complex reality cannot be compressed into facile tourist language.

A Symbolic Dining Row for the Crocodiles

Beside the stump, a row is arranged for the crocodiles, with rice, salt, water and empty spaces. The point is not to feed actual creatures. Ba urges the

others to think of the crocodile not merely as monstrous hunger but as a terrifying question about life. This magical-symbolic scene does not domesticate the deadly memory of water burial; it raises the question of what violence means. Criticism must preserve the crocodiles' historical role in the story: the emblem of a shared mouthful does not erase earlier deaths.

Leaves Buried in Earth as an Archive

After the meal, the leaves are buried in soil beside the river. A clear metaphor arises between a register on paper and a register of leaves: institutional written memory on one side, perishable organic memory on the other. The children inscribe small marks on the leaves, not complete names. Thus the archive is deliberately incomplete and belongs to the material life cycle of its medium. Dissolving into the soil need not mean final oblivion; it may also carry the possibility of uncertain renewal.

The Mark of Smell: A New Medium from Taste to Memory

Meera explains that taste lingers on the tongue, while smell makes memory return. The sign of an extinguished scent points towards the next narrative unit. The narrator joins the steam of cooked food, damp leaves, workers' sweat and the aroma of the hearth in one sequence. Earlier focal images included "the theft of voices" and "the taste of salt"; smell now becomes a new bearer of memory. This continuity across several senses is the chapter's major structural connection.

The Unsettled Social Value of the Communal Feast

The characters eat together publicly, but the festival should not be read as proof of a total social transformation. Obstacles persist: women's labour within the dining arrangement, an outside project's proposal to sell tickets, and the elder's mistrust. The chapter demonstrates the capacity to form partial relationships within a short span of time. It does not depict sustained repetition in realistic daily life. The feast should therefore be read as a promising experiment in shared eating, not evidence of permanent social harmony.

Conclusion: From the Document of Memory to the Leaf of a Meal

From the vigil over names to marks left by a meal, the story projects a persistent social question through new senses. Mouthfuls of rice, the veins of leaves, hearth ash and traces of smell leave a prolonged impression on the reader. Narrative devices that once resembled objective entries in a record now become experiences shared through touch, taste and scent. But the next chapter, "The Shared Plate," returns to the fear still resisting

common meals. This recurrence will make clear the limits of the present chapter's hopeful moment.

Critical Section 232 | Original Chapter 131 — The Shared Plate

A Second Attempt at a Meal of Equality

After Chapter 130 has presented a communal meal, Chapter 131 begins once again with preparations for a shared plate. The repetition is not pointless: the earlier dispute over social propriety did not transform everyday conduct in its entirety. Yet the narrative gives little explicit indication of the interval separating these two episodes of organising a meal. A reader may therefore understand the new gathering as a further social experiment while also recognising an editorial weakness in the recurrence of neighbouring events. The development of the narrative must be examined without erasing either side of this ambiguity.

Touching in Kabaddi and Remaining at the Plate

The narrator observes that in kabaddi one must touch and return, whereas at the plate one must touch and remain. This is a remarkably subtle self-commentary on the grammar of the game that has governed the narrative. Earlier, crossing a line signified courage; here, the ability to stay together after crossing a boundary becomes the more difficult undertaking. The duration of a social relationship extends beyond a brief turn in a game and assumes the shape of everyday coexistence. In this single sentence resides the chapter's distinctive contribution to narratology.

A Circular Seating Arrangement and the Abolition of the Raised Seat

Long leaves are laid out for the meal, but the children erase the straight line of diners and form a circle. The stump, the stone of names and a lamp occupy the centre. This spatial alteration is highly significant: a common level challenges both the vertical structure of judgment in the courtroom and the higher and lower places of caste-based dining. Bodies sit at the same height, and elevated social positions disappear from the visual composition. Nevertheless, sitting in a circle does not automatically abolish every disparity of power. The subsequent scenes disclose precisely this limitation.

The Elderly Brahmin's Hesitating Hand

An elderly Brahmin pauses beside his leaf-plate, particularly when his gaze falls upon a young man from the leatherworkers' settlement. The narrator records his perspiration and motionless fingers. The portrayal does not turn him into a monstrous antagonist; it makes visible a conflict among ingrained habit, fear for lineage and genuine hunger. Agreement to eat together is not an effortless feeling but an uncomfortable decision.

Ananya does not compel him. She asks him to name his fear. At this point the narrative's ethical insistence differs from a scene of dramatic punishment.

Writing the Names of Fear and Hunger

Ananya first asks the elder to enter the name of his fear—'lineage'—and then asks him to name his hunger. The order of these two questions demonstrates the growing maturity of the novel's register. The record no longer preserves only the names of those who suffer; it also records the fears that reproduce injustice. Once the two lines have been written, the elder touches the food. The method of questioning proves more effective in the narrative than a forcible declaration that inherited obligations must be renounced, because the decision remains in the character's own hands.

The Small Exchange of Greens and Jaggery

The young man from the leatherworkers' settlement offers the elder some greens prepared by his mother; in response, the elder extends his own jaggery. No speech brings about the alteration in their relationship: it occurs through a small movement of material things. A prohibition against touch enters the shared experience of taste. The narrative supplies neither celebratory drums nor easy triumph; it preserves the silence of hesitation, making the moment of change unexpectedly credible. Accepting one morsel is no guarantee of lasting social transformation, but within the scene it creates a substantial link in a chain of possibility.

The Story of the Women Remaining Outside the Circle

Some women cannot join the meal because they fear household propriety, fathers-in-law, husbands, their daughters' marriages and village opinion. Meera approaches them without forcing their participation. She proposes recording the names of those unable to sit, as well as the names of those preventing them. This is a crucial authorial choice: within a scene apparently celebrating the triumph of a common plate, the narrative preserves a record of those who could not enter it. The shadows outside the celebration are not erased by its brightness, and the social complexity of the story survives.

The Meaning of the List: 'Home', 'Shame', 'Rice Vessels'

Instead of providing personal names, the women name the sources of restraint: home, shame, utensils, daughters' marriages and the village's judgment. In this compact list, private constraint becomes recognisable as social institution. A narrative that had earlier paused over the missing name of a leatherworker woman now names the reasons living women are

prevented from participating. The narrator thus constructs a new kind of record. Its subject is not merely 'who ate' but also 'who could not eat'.

The Limits of Batuknath's Legal Cunning

Batuknath Hariharan understands that it is difficult to prevent, through litigation, two hands from meeting upon a single leaf-plate. Contempt, unlawful assembly and other legal classifications pass through his mind, but the thought 'they are only eating' becomes the narrative's irony. A character who made the vocabulary of law into an instrument of obstruction now confronts a human action that renders him speechless. Without requiring an overt act of violence from this external authority, the author exposes the limits of its language.

From Chandrapal's Calculations to Childhood Memory

Chandrapal initially regards the communal meal as an opportunity to produce donation receipts, but drops of cooked greens appear in place of the figures on his screen. He remembers an old incident involving segregated rows at school. This turn brings the character's background of wrongdoing into contact with an earlier human wound, without allowing inward suffering to establish innocence. The reader sees both the persistence of his greed and the humiliation he once experienced. Such double focalisation prevents the antagonist from becoming a figure of only one colour.

Satyavrat's Place at the End of the Row and His Changed Role

Satyavrat sits at the far end and writes that a mouth trained to read law must learn equality in eating. His long moral journey finds a new scene within that brief sentence. In the earlier chapter devoted to testimony he acknowledged his silence; here he shares a place at the meal in practice. Although writing remains an old habit of his, setting down the pen to eat is the more decisive performance. The narrator replaces an official's superior seat with the modesty of companionship.

Magical Presence and Moisture on the Stone

The smell of flattened rice and curd, the steam rising from cooked rice, and moisture condensing upon the stone establish an extraordinary connection between the names of the dead and the food of the living. A communal sensation arises as though the tastes of those who underwent burial in water have returned. This is, however, an imaginative form of the characters' perception, not a separate claim that physical rebirth has demonstrably occurred. The stone's warmth, described as resembling bodily heat, produces a magical-realist effect through which remembrance of the dead mingles with the living experience of eating together.

Returning the Remaining Grains to the Soil

After the meal, the uneaten grains on every leaf-plate are collected and mixed into the earth. The action both discourages disrespect for food and recalls the cycle linking soil and life. A small detail—a participant keeping a hand in the soil longer than necessary—transforms the event from a display of moral virtue into bodily experience. The earlier scenes of seeds and the earth of the paddy field of judgment are recalled here. Grain returns from field to plate and from plate to soil.

The Register of Unresolved Fears and the Next Stage

What matters more than the number of people who joined the shared plate is why others remained absent. Ananya preserves their uncertainty in her register; the chapter therefore does not end by claiming a complete victory for equality. Resistance is still alive within the village's private life. The expectation aroused by the next title, 'The Republic of the Kitchen', grows out of this very incompleteness. The struggle to turn one day's common meal into an enduring arrangement for cooking and eating remains unfinished.

Conclusion: The Capacity to Remain Together after Touch

The chapter's most distinctive proposition is not simply a declaration against caste but the temporal challenge of remaining together after contact. The difference between the brief touch of kabaddi and the prolonged proximity of a shared plate opens another dimension of social narration. The elder's hesitating hand, the young man's greens, the women's fears outside the circle, Batuknath's ineffective words and Chandrapal's recollection depict the beginnings of a complicated transformation rather than complete moral unanimity. The question of the narrative's forgotten names returns in the actual nearness created by food.

Inter-sectional Discussion: Soil, Throat, Memory and Shared Food

Chapters 124–131 form three successive levels. At the first, the leaf of Tattvachintamani leads to the fire of evidence, and from its ashes arises the paddy field of judgment. The second opens the everyday story of deprivation through food, hunger and thirst. The third tests human touch and caste distance by means of salt, taste and the common plate. In this movement, the prestige of classical learning remains a source of dialogue within the story-world; the chief creative consequence becomes visible in the conditions under which living people eat and coexist.

The material method of these eight chapters merits particular attention. A red line on a leaf, ashes from the fire, seeds, a panicle of rice, an empty

bowl, smoke from the hearth, a well-bucket, the ring of an empty water vessel, a grain of salt, a palm-leaf manuscript and shared curd and greens: each object expands its meaning as the story proceeds. The register's lists connect them, but the list does not become the hero. Objects acquire significance through the particular voices of people whose bodies, labour and shame are bound to them.

Two principal tensions in narrative time are evident. At the end of Chapter 124 a promise to discover the name of an unnamed leatherworker woman shifts immediately to the field episode of Chapter 125. The rice transplanted in Chapter 125 is then shown bearing ears on the following morning in Chapter 126, although the agricultural interval of several months has not been marked. The first displacement may be read as a shift in the site of inquiry, the second as a poetic compression of time. Nevertheless, the absence of definite signals in the source text also needs to be registered as textual incongruity. Criticism does not resolve that uncertainty by inventing intervening events.

The folk songs and the principal events are closely connected, though not always in full correspondence. The rhythms of transplantation and harvest, an earlier recollection of elephant and crocodile, the empty plate, thirst, the oath of salt, a song celebrating a meal, and the folk cadence of Sama-Chakeva establish an anticipated moral horizon. The main prose cuts across that horizon to show continuing failures: hungry people omitted from donor plaques, unsafe water in the well and women unable to sit together. Thus the brightness of song and the incompletion of prose form an important two-voiced structure.

The actions of the characters repeatedly reveal Ananya's interrogative awareness, Ba's memory of soil, Meera's bodily autonomy, Devika's immediate demand for food, Aruni's guilt as an engineer, Gop's doubts concerning records and Satyavrat's choice to sit at the back. Readers encounter no single person's decisive command; they observe the possibility of change arising through small acts performed by different people. Yet opposing figures—donors, policy promoters and caste guardians—are, in several episodes, quickly silenced by similar formulations. This repetition carries a risk of dialogic imbalance within the novel's polyphony.

The shared-plate chapter is the decisive open ending of this sequence. The small exchange of greens from a young man of the leatherworkers' settlement and jaggery from an elderly Brahmin is a living instant of change, yet the women's fears concerning household, marriage, shame and utensils persist. The story therefore refuses to mistake one day's common meal for complete emancipation. It records the obstacles that survive. The possibility of a new kitchen arrangement and the question of everyday

rights remain open for the following chapter, 'The Republic of the Kitchen'.

Critical Section 233 | Original Chapter 132 — The Republic of the Kitchen

From the Shared Plate to the Shared Kitchen: The Story's Next Turn

In Original Chapter 131, the practice of eating together from a shared plate exposed fears sustained by the caste order. Chapter 132 does not stop there and declare that moment a complete victory. Instead, the author asks whose responsibility it remains to cook the food, serve it and clean the vessels once people have eaten together. This subsequent question carries the narrative beyond the symbolism of communal dining into the structure of power within the household. The setting changes, but the social causes of the preceding chapter's conflict remain continuously present.

The Kitchen Door: A Small Court within the Home

The narrator recalls, in a single sequence, the raised veranda of an old house, separate drinking water, food served to labourers, the plain meals of widows and bread made by a domestic worker's hands. In this compact catalogue, food signifies not merely taste but the hierarchy operating within the home. The 'court' ceases to be an exclusively external institution. The kitchen itself becomes the place where decisions about who may touch whom are repeated daily. This spatial transformation enables the novel to test large public controversies at the level of apparently minor domestic events.

Ba's Question of the Utensils and Dramatic Anticipation

Ba immediately raises the question of washing up when the community celebrates eating together. This remark has structural significance because it anticipates the closing scene: the reader understands from the outset that the real test will be not the attractive picture of a common meal but the labour following it. The author introduces a small object—the used eating vessel—at the beginning and makes it decisive at the end. Utensils have served as instruments of social subordination; cleaning them through a new distribution of labour rearranges the agency of those involved.

The Stories of Grain: Restoring Humanity to Ingredients

A farmer's sack, flattened rice saved during a flood and greens brought by a young woman from the leatherworkers' neighbourhood enter the gathering in succession. Every ingredient is accompanied by the memory of its bearer, so the materials of cooking cease to be merely entries in an inventory. The dust rising from a deposited sack, the difficult remembrance associated with rescued rice and the hands formerly

excluded from preparing greens give different histories of labour to the same scene. Without particular human experiences, the collective meal might remain a decorative list. The story attempts to avoid that danger.

The Young Leatherworker Woman and the Elderly Brahmin's Ghee

An elderly Brahmin decides to contribute ghee from his household to the pan in which greens supplied by a young woman from the leatherworkers' settlement are being cooked. This quiet moment of social change takes place through the mingling of ingredients rather than a prolonged sermon. The sound of ghee hissing in the vessel becomes the audible centre of a shared silence. The elder's voice makes no claim of triumph; it admits embarrassment. The scene thus opens personal transformation as a possibility, not as proof that the caste system has been abolished in its entirety.

The Narrative Use of Smell as a Carrier of Memory

Smoke and mingled aromas become sensory forces even more powerful than sight. Things brought from different settlements, homes and hands enter the same cooking vessel, but no family or caste name can be attached to their fragrance. The narrator makes this experience a way of rendering collective justice perceptible. Nevertheless, equality of smell is not equality of social ownership. The need to redistribute labour within the central action exposes the possible limits of this symbolic equality.

Men's Work in the Kitchen and the Reversal of Roles

Women remain central to the cooking, but male characters are assigned cutting, washing, grinding, tending the fire and cleaning vessels. The visual arrangement of these tasks is especially significant. Aruni questions the habit of considering domestic work insignificant in comparison with his own professional experience as an engineer. Although the redistribution occurs during a single communal event, the episode offers a useful beginning for reconstructing everyday practice. The social argument acquires force through the movement of actual work.

The Aesthetics of Numbers and a Mixture without Caste Labels

Five hearths, seven pans, grain from several settlements, a widow's salt, firewood brought by a Musahar boy and fruit from outside: the narrator builds an extensive inventory of quantities and sources. The counting differs from the exploitative culture of metrics associated with the memorial app, since every object here retains its social origin. Yet the numerical rhythm also produces the image of an ideal union. Those who still dissent—the two people sitting at a distance—prevent the representation from becoming a picture of complete harmony.

The First Leaf before the Unnamed: A Place for the Absent Character

The first helping is placed before the unnamed stone, where no living body waits to eat. The empty place becomes a mode of representing the dead, but it cannot be understood adequately as a simple religious offering. Here the narrative gives social absence the first position in a public order and devises a visual language in which those deprived of their names receive the place of honour. The contrast between the steam of food and the absence of a body is painful: the presence of grain cannot bring back the missing person.

The Limits of Consent: Two People Sitting Apart

Those who remain too frightened by caste restrictions to share the food are not forced to eat. The narrative does not conceal their hesitation; it proposes asking each person to name the fear. Creatively, this is an essential distinction. If a successful communal programme assumed that everyone had changed immediately, the psychology of its characters would become hollow. The distance kept by these two people is evidence of conflict still to come, while the meaning of a right remains separate from compelled participation.

The Dream Screens of the Distant Tricksters

Batuknath's dream court, Chandrapal's food-delivery screen and Lau's nutrient-pill version of 'New Horizon' unfold at locations far removed from the communal kitchen. These parallel cuts show the moral pressure of the village meal entering the private perceptions of the antagonists. The dream screens, however, cannot be taken as external historical changes. They are figurative projections of the characters' fears, greed and memories. Through the cuts between two locations, the story connects events in the village with remote economic structures.

Washing the Utensils: The Final Test of the Social Experiment

Those who have always been made to clear other people's dirty plates are invited to sit, while those claiming prestige are assigned the work of cleaning. Ba's remark at the opening is fulfilled here as an event. Scratches on vessels scrubbed with ash, and the gleam of brass, place the material reality of labour before the reader. The chapter arrives at its most tangible consequence through this scene. Eating together was a momentary festival; undertaking the cleaning together becomes a genuine test of relationships.

A New Rule and the Narrative's Incompleteness

A rule is entered in the register: whoever eats must cook, whoever cooks must eat, and whoever eats must also wash up. The word 'republic' thus transforms the language of political constitutions into domestic practice;

the title names an experiment in governance, not merely a joke. The text nevertheless does not yet disclose how extensively one communal kitchen can change inequalities maintained in ordinary households. At the end, the route opens from memories of food towards a public dramatic form, giving the next dispute over performance a social body formed in the kitchen.

Critical Section 234 | Original Chapter 133 — The Invitation to the Videha Theatre Festival

The Sudden Expansion from Kitchen to Stage

From the intimate domestic world of hearth, plate and utensils in Chapter 132, the following chapter moves to an invitation from the Videha Theatre Festival. The principal narrative purpose is not simply to introduce another event. It raises the problem of retelling the preceding social experiences in public form. How can the village carry its experience to other audiences without making suffering into a spectacle once again? This conflict makes the new setting necessary. The narrator presents the story in the act of preparing to become theatre.

The Invitation Letter: Opportunity and Appropriation

The letter from the Videha Theatre Festival offers the popular memory of Garh Narikel a wider audience, while at the same time opening the possibility of control by an outside organisation over the institution, stage, lighting, tickets and presentation. Because of this double significance, the letter is more than ordinary narrative news: it is the entrance to another conflict. Earlier episodes concerning the memorial tender, sound collection and research team remain in memory when the letter is read. The story does not automatically regard an institutional invitation as innocent.

'First the Game, Then the Stage': Ananya's Method of Organisation

Instead of professional theatre practitioners, Ananya proposes the kabaddi players as performers. This choice moves the narrative's central symbol into another genre: kabaddi, regulated by breath, will provide the rhythm of dramatic performance. Against the décor and timetable of the outside organisers, the children give priority to bodily rehearsal. The decision connects the form of theatre to the village's practices of popular justice, without necessarily denying the genuine skills of professional performers.

Remembering One Hundred and Thirty-Two Chapters: Self-Reflection

Aruni raises the difficulty of bringing 132 chapters onto the stage, and Ba replies that the chapters will now become acts. The conversation is an unmistakable instance of self-reference: the novel brings its own preceding sequence into what its characters say. The characters appear to understand that their story is being shaped, and they debate its theatrical version. This intervention is unusual within a realist story-world, but it also constitutes

a declaration of intent to transfer the heavy burden of a long novel's memory from one medium into another.

The Crocodile Image of the Summary: Rejecting Abridgment

Ananya explicitly says that the performance will not become a summary, for a summary, like a crocodile, chews the flesh and leaves only the bones. This should not be dismissed as a mere exaggeration against summarising. It is the work's commentary upon its own medium. Theatre must grapple with vast material in little time, yet Ananya insists that each act retain its scenes, names, pauses and breath. This problem of medium brings the ethics of selection, omission and theatrical pace into the foreground.

The Children's Rehearsal: Bodies Become the Writing of the Story

The players utter the names of earlier chapters, hold their breath, cross lines and change forms. A body bending beneath the invisible branch of a felled grove, a player running towards the water while naming the crocodile, and a turn stopping at 'Gangesha' translate narrated events into bodily action. The most important moment is the bending beneath a branch that no longer exists. An absent object becomes visible through the posture of a body. This is a theatrical rendering of the novel's central metaphor of names and absences.

Intention before Script: The Question of Rights

Asked when the performance will take place, Ananya replies that the breath is still being prepared. The time demanded by festival management comes into conflict with the time required for victims' testimony. Meera clarifies consent, Devika insists that the unnamed receive the first place, Ira speaks of foreign spectators' duty to listen, and Gop identifies limits on control over copies. These conditions do not annihilate artistic freedom. They establish the responsibility that freedom bears towards testimony.

Not an Imitation of the Villain: The Problem of Playing Batuknath

The children want to play Batuknath's role with laughter, but Ananya prevents them from turning him into a buffoon. If amusement consumes the moral seriousness of wrongdoing, spectators may go home regarding grave injustice as entertainment. A quiet player who speaks little is therefore selected, his lowered eyes to become a visual language of contempt. In this choice, dramatic composition moves beyond externally advertised wickedness and shapes character through signals of inward restraint.

Two Actors for Raghav: A Divided Character

Two people will perform Raghav: one will become his voice, while the other will disappear. In this conception, the disjointed self associated with digital crime is not confined to a single body on stage. Message and silence, presence and erasure reproduce the technical devices already encountered in the plot as a theatrical double. Whether this division will take precisely the same form in the actual performance remains uncertain. The plans of Chapter 133 therefore need comparison with the script and production of Chapters 134–135.

The Problem of Language: Lau Kin-Hung's Few Lines

When the children ask how Lau's character will speak Maithili, Ba replies by concentrating on the multilingual nature of greed. A shining glass bowl, in which names fall without the sound of coins, becomes a dramatic sign. This imagined scene portrays foreign capital principally through control of accounts rather than difference of language. Yet it also risks compressing an antagonist's complexity into a single image of avarice. The criticism registers this possible simplification.

Satyavrat's Silence and a Child's Request

A child seated at the back raises a hand to volunteer for Satyavrat's role because he himself speaks little. Casting appears to depend not on a drama teacher's assessment of mimetic ability, but on experience of human silence. Satyavrat's actual remorse becomes a bodily posture of listening rather than a ready-made speech for the actor. For spectators, silence on stage may be an empty stretch of time. The reader of the original novel, however, knows of the years of institutional guilt lying behind it.

The First Line: The Name of the Reflection

At the close of the chapter an opening line of the dramatic script is devised: water will stand at the centre of the stage, and each entrant must first speak the name of their reflection. Entry into the play thus becomes a test of self-recognition. The water on stage is not a substitute for an actual river; it is simultaneously mirror, examination of the self and remembrance of the earlier water burials. This material object gives the following chapter a definite visual centre through which the story's often abstract ethical claims can take visible form.

The Plan of Time and an Announced Future

Chapter 133 announces in advance the preparation of the script, its subsequent performance and the continuation of the narrative beyond that performance. Such foretelling reduces the suspense of whether an event will happen, while making the process of composition more

transparent. The reader's attention shifts from whether a performance will occur to how events will be transformed into it. This is a self-reflexive feature of the work. At times, however, the narrator's excessive explanation limits the force with which later chapters might otherwise unfold for themselves.

Critical Section 235 | Original Chapter 134 — The Kabaddi Players' Dramatic Script

Three Days of Silent Drums and the Breath of Writing

After the invitation to the Videha Theatre Festival, the drums remain silent for three days, creating an interval of quiet. This suspension is time for preparation, but the narrator also presents it as a way to avoid haste when writing the names of the victims. The players' circle and the sounds of their individual breathing begin a bodily text before spoken dialogue. The invitation of Chapter 133 is transformed here from a point of social tension into creative labour.

The Title 'Pahara' and the Centrality of Breath

The play is named 'Pahara', with the subtitle 'The Kabaddi Players' Dramatic Script'. Its protagonist will not be a person but breath. This statement displaces the traditional centre of character-based narrative. Breath is the minimum material condition of life, the foundation of kabaddi's rules and a reminder of the dead who can no longer breathe. Through these three meanings, the play's internal story is brought together in a single pulse. Yet deploying the same symbol everywhere may also make distinct experiences appear unduly similar.

Deleting 'Spectator' and Revising the Sentence

Ira's first line contains the word 'spectator'; Ananya strikes it out and substitutes 'witness'. This actual revision within the novel is a decisive event in its theory of performance. The wish to turn those who merely watch into people who accept responsibility begins with a change of one word. Instead of delivering a comprehensive theoretical lecture, the author shows a modest act of editing. Its implications will be tested in subsequent chapters when the performance leads towards public testimony.

The Cast: People, Objects, Breath and Absence

Breath, the stump, water, a crocodile, Chandrapal's percentage, Raghav's vanished message, Satyavrat's silence and the feet of labourers all appear in the script's cast. Such a list transforms the familiar characters of the novel into the unusual dramatis personae of a play. Principal human figures lose their monopoly over speech; objects and absences acquire the right to narrate. One choice is particularly significant: the list places a 'cage' where caste might otherwise appear. This theatrical decision resists making a social structure into the inescapable identity of living people.

The Circular Ground, Black Strip of Water and Empty Cage

The stage is planned as a circular field, with the stump, black water and kitchen smoke on three sides and an empty cage on the fourth. The arrangement brings together major spaces and constraints from the earlier narrative: burial in water, bodily labour and the boundaries of caste. The circle alters the audience's central perspective, allowing the scene to be viewed from every side. The performance's ethical claim therefore resides not only in dialogue but also in entrances, sightlines and the distribution of seats.

Planning Nine Scenes: The Ethics of Narrative Selection

Nine scenes are outlined: the morning after erosion, the yellow notice, Gangesha's question, the memorial app, the procession of false ghosts, the nameless planet, the republic of the kitchen, the elephant and crocodile, and the return to Earth. Each represents a different struggle in the novel. Yet the list necessarily selects. Illness, other river subplots and the fuller lives of numerous ordinary characters may fall outside the centre of the stage. Despite the script's insistence that it is 'not a summary', theatrical construction cannot be wholly free from selection.

The Yellow Notice: Paper in Performance

A government notice flies onto the stage like a bird, while Batuknath's lawyers, fashioned as leaves, circle around it. The letters on the paper will sweat, but the paper will not be set alight. Through this choice, administrative violence becomes a bodily experience of labour and fear rather than a sensational spectacle of burning. The yellow colour recalls the earlier tender. Paper itself becomes a living stage object, questioning the power of official language to declare a place empty.

The Empty Cage and the Light of Gangesha

In the scene devoted to Gangesha's question, an empty cage inscribed with caste hangs above the stage; no substantial statue of Gangesha is brought on. The question takes the form of light falling on the bars, and the bars' shadows become letters. This theatrical vision challenges the earlier tendency to suppress lived truths beneath statues of celebrated individuals. Yet when a historical person becomes light and a question, the complexity of that person's individual life may again dissolve into abstraction. The artistic choice has force, but it cannot stand in for an entire life.

The Memorial App: A Coin That Changes Colour

Chandrapal's percentage becomes a rolling silver coin, which turns black after the protest of Ujjwal's spirit. The theatrical transformation of financial brokerage is unmistakable: money visibly encounters shame in

the face of bodily memory. The scene also employs an exceptionally accessible moral symbol, for a blackened coin does not explain the full structure of the network of wrongdoing. The distance between theatrical convenience and the novel's more complex analysis needs to be noted.

Breaking Character in the Procession of False Ghosts

The script reuses the procession of false ghosts at the moment when actors speak the actual names of their parents. A play within a play breaks apart when the performers abandon their roles and speak as inheritors of their own histories. The earlier episode is thus not merely repeated. It creates a limit for future spectators: representation acknowledges its constructed quality and opens a path towards testimony.

Excessive Brightness on the Nameless Planet

The dream planet is to be staged not in complete darkness but in excessive cleanliness and light. In that brightness, homes, bodies and labour become numbers, exposing the violence concealed within the projected publicity of 'New Horizon'. Light, ordinarily taken as a sign of knowledge, becomes an instrument of the destruction of memory. This reversal is inventive: terror needs neither the open jaws of a crocodile nor overt darkness when an apparently innocent arrangement of glass is sufficient.

The Final Scene, 'Earth Again', and the Unfinished Story

The script ends with a choice of Earth beside a new Channa sprout, but the words 'The End' are refused. As long as someone still has breath, their story remains: with this proposition, the curtain cannot simply fall. The unfinished ending leaves the production open to further testimony. For criticism, however, a question remains: who will determine the limits of spectators' actual participation? Every rule established in the script still needs to be observed in practice when the work is performed.

Later Changes to the Script: An Issue for the Reader

The script is prepared in this chapter, but one point needs particular attention: the sequence of written scenes will not correspond word for word to the order of the later actual performance. This chapter provides the base text for critical comparison. Had the author supplied an account of revision between rehearsal and staging, the changes would be more readily intelligible; at present their cause remains unstated. Readers may regard the gap either as independent artistic reorganisation or as an inconsistency in the continuity of the original plan.

Critical Section 236 | Original Chapter 135 — The Staging of the Videha Theatre Festival

From the Written Text to a Public Embodiment

The dramatic text of "Vigil," prepared in Chapter 134, is performed before the public in this chapter. Its first difficulty is whether an ethical proposition set down in writing can produce an effect between living players and spectators. The narrator connects each scene with the audience's actual responses, the performers' sweat and the dust of the ground. The central claim, therefore, is not that performance simply repeats the script's arrangement. Rather, acting transforms that arrangement into a reciprocal production of meaning, in which the event can be altered by those who witness it.

The Festival's Previous 132 Acts: A Chronological Difficulty

The opening states that all 132 earlier acts of the Videha Theatre Festival had already been performed on different stages. Yet the script of this play was only just completed in the preceding chapter, while Chapter 133 described the order of its proposed performances in the future, as part of the reply to an invitation. The festival may possess an independent history that has become entangled with the novel's recollection of chapter and act numbers. The text, however, offers no clear chronological bridge. The discrepancy should be recorded as an unstable signal of narrative time, not erased by the critic through an unsupported factual correction.

Rejecting the Raised Stage: The Circular Ground

The children refuse the organisers' red curtain, lighting tower, guests' gallery and sponsor's board. Instead, a black kabaddi line occupies the centre of a circular playing ground. This substitution breaks the visual language in which actors stand above and spectators remain below. The writer makes the architecture of performance an instrument of social thought. Nevertheless, a circular arena does not, by its shape alone, make social power equal. Whether the change has any substantive force depends on the audience's right to speak after the actors have finished. The spatial symbol must therefore be judged alongside the social practice it enables.

From "Kabaddi" to "Names": A Transformation of Sound

The first player enters chanting "kabaddi, kabaddi," but the utterance gradually becomes "names, names." Through this phonetic transformation, a rule of the game turns visibly into a ritual of remembrance. From every direction comes the answer "Present" at the first name-stone: a repeated expression from the earlier fictional world

now becomes the stage's collective chorus. This alteration in sound is among the chapter's most effective dramatic openings, for the movement of meaning is accomplished through the voiced action itself, without the need for an explanatory speech. The game's breath thus becomes the means by which names are restored to hearing.

The Absence of a Crocodile Mask and the Use of Shadow

Neither an actual animal nor a fabricated mask represents the crocodile. One player crawls on his stomach, while his shadow assumes the shape of a crocodile. The scene suggests that the narrative's crocodile is both a bodily creature and a figure for the violence of time, administration and forgetting. A mask might have confined the spectator's attention to an animal's outline; the shadow leaves its meanings more open. What emerges is a many-sided theatrical image achieved with minimal material means. The performance thereby keeps its central symbol from becoming a merely literal creature onstage.

A Water Burial Without Water and the Body's Upward Movement

No water is brought onto the ground for the scene of water burial; the players' circling breaths create a sense of its presence. Instead of falling to the earth, the figure described as drowned rises and sits beside the name-stone. This reversal in the direction of bodily movement points away from a display of death and towards a return to presence in memory. The scene does not assert that death has truly been overcome. It gives spectators room to contemplate the emotional distance between a death and the naming of the dead. Nor does it reduce the fear of the original river to a decorative simulation of its waters.

Gangesha's Empty Seat and the Uncomfortable Questions

Gangesha is represented not by an embodied actor or an idol but by an empty seat and the suggestion of a leaf of the Tattvachintamani held in a palm. A girl raises questions of birth, marriage, caste and evidence; the voice of Charmakarni comes from behind. Such theatrical questioning is not a substitute for verification of historical claims: it is a public echo of contested memory within the fictional world. The discomfort of certain pandits sitting among the spectators becomes an actual social reaction to the play. It cannot, however, be treated as independent proof of anyone's historical culpability. The staging makes controversy audible while retaining the limits of what it can establish.

Batuknath's Leaf-Lawyer and the Audience's Questions

In the performance, Batuknath opens a volume, but dry leaves fly from within and land in the spectators' laps. Each leaf raises questions about who

owns the trust, who guards memory and who benefits from it. The scene humorously exposes an institutional tendency to control names, though its artistic satire also complicates the character's inner remorse. The earlier script proposed a quiet, deliberate portrayal of Batuknath; here the part is given to "the most agile boy." That is a definite departure in the direction of the character, rather than an identical enactment of the previous plan. The difference remains visible in a careful comparison of the two chapters.

Raghav's Silent Message and the Paper Leaves

Raghav's scene is composed of wordless gestures. The players attempt to communicate a message, but their messages turn into leaves and fall to the ground. The business of deleting digital evidence thus returns in the visual materiality of paper. The connection between Raghav's vanished messages and leaves from the tree stump, established in the main narrative, is now available as an acting device. Repeated images awaken the spectators' memory. Yet the right to interpret the messages within the play becomes bound once again to local testimony. The visible sign cannot, by itself, replace those whose accounts give it meaning.

Lau and Broom in Identical White Costumes

Lau Kin-Hung and Broom, representing foreign capital and consultancy, enter in shining white clothes. Their language offers promises of security, cleanliness and a future on a nameless planet. The excessive whiteness works as a theatrical contrast to the darkness of the wrongdoing associated with them. Yet dressing two different figures alike also merges their distinct economic and intellectual strategies. The image gains immediate symbolic clarity at the expense of some social specificity in their characterisation. That tension between the force of the symbol and the differentiation of characters is present in the theatrical description itself.

Differences Between the Script and the New Sequence of Scenes

The newly written scenes in Chapter 134 assigned separate places to the yellow notice, the procession of false ghosts, the republic of the kitchen, the elephant and crocodile, and "Earth Again." The description of the performance instead gives particular prominence, in a different order, to water burial, Batuknath, Raghav, Lau, Satyavrat's empty chair and the final communal game of kabaddi. This textual variation may admit artistic re-editing, but the author supplies no explicit rehearsal sequence connecting the two arrangements. It would therefore be careless to describe the planned script and the performance as though their orders were exactly the same.

Satyavrat's Empty Chair and the Contradiction of Representation

In the written script, a boy seated at the rear had raised his hand to play Satyavrat. In the account of the staging, no one plays him: an empty chair is instead placed in the middle. The difference should not be silently covered over by treating it only as an elevated symbol of "silence." The empty chair certainly makes a powerful image, marking both the absence of office and the need to listen. But the earlier account of choosing an actor has clearly changed. Recording the inconsistency permits a more attentive reading of the novel's self-questioning theatrical construction, rather than assuming a continuity the text does not provide.

Preventing Applause and the Collective Ending of an Endless Game

The final scene consists of kabaddi played in its pure form. Every player who falls receives a name, and the whole ground assumes the rhythm of collective breathing. The organisers want applause to close the programme, but the children resist this conclusion. The request to write the next name, instead of applauding, establishes that the play's ultimate purpose is not acclaim but an unbroken movement of testimony. Such an open ending takes the reader beyond the stage and towards a subsequent chapter in social life. The game ends as a performance, yet refuses to declare the work of remembrance finished.

The Performance's Result: New Entries for Omitted Names

After the performance, elderly people, women, young people and migrants want to add names that had been left out. This modest event makes the play's necessary incompleteness palpable. The script that appeared to give final form to the preceding chapters begins changing under the pressure of new questions about public memory. Even the depiction of its own chapter number increasing within the story becomes a pointed device of self-reflection. Yet open participation leaves a further question unanswered: whose testimony will find its way onto the stage, and whose will not? The performance opens an archive without guaranteeing equal access to it.

Critical Section 237 | Original Chapter 136 — The Silence After the Applause

The End of the Performance and the Story's Second Beginning

Although Chapter 135 ends with an attempt to prevent applause, the next chapter begins by describing applause that actually occurs. Some hands clap, others stop midway, while some spectators wipe their eyes. These different responses turn what might have been a single moment of closure into a scene of many voices. The text also leaves a small tension in the sequence of events: did the attempt to stop the applause succeed, or succeed only in part? No definite answer is supplied. The uncertainty brings out the difference between public emotion and the discipline planned for an artistic event.

Silence as an Ethical Remainder, Not a Failure

The organisers' address of thanks falters in its opening sentence. What would ordinarily become a formal speech of praise at a cultural event changes into an appeal to leave room on the stage for omitted names. Silence is therefore not passive emptiness; it marks a form of narrative pressure. The writer links the silence after speech with the inheritance of silence explored in earlier chapters. This time silence is being protected, and yet new testimony is taking birth within it. The absence of immediate words becomes the condition for a more responsible hearing.

The Performer's Sweat and the Afterlife of the Role

The boy who played the elephant looks at his hands as though the crocodile's grip still remains upon them. Sweat onstage is an ordinary product of work, but within the performer it also becomes a bodily indication of the guilt associated with the role. The player cannot simply return to his private disposition the instant the performance ends. The chapter produces an image in which an enacted character continues to dwell in the actor's body. Through this physical persistence the actual ethical effect of theatre becomes visible, without requiring the narrative to claim that an actor's experience is identical to that of a victim.

A Second Performance Around the Register

An elderly woman says her husband's name was omitted; another person recalls a different account of his brother's drowning; a woman speaks of the pain of a living daughter deprived of her name by her own household. The actors remove their roles and sit beside the children's register. This is a “performance after the performance,” but the written script no longer controls it. People begin to add their own experiences. The boundary of

theatrical narrative opens towards the next possible text of public memory, which cannot be completed by staging what was known before the spectators spoke.

Satyavrat and the Boy Who Played Him

Satyavrat warns his young actor that applause raised over suffering should make the listener doubly cautious. In this encounter, the actual character and his theatrical representative stand together within a single scene. The difficulty is that Chapter 135 had said no one played Satyavrat, whereas here a thin-spectacled boy is said to have performed the role. The contradiction ought not to be concealed. It presents either an editorial inconsistency within the theatrical intertext or a problem produced by the changing focus of the descriptions of the scenes. The ethical exchange is significant, but it does not resolve the discrepancy.

Chandrapal at the Ticket Window: The Boundary Between Inside and Outside

Chandrapal stands outside the auditorium looking at his face in the glass of the ticket window. Inside, the performers have portrayed him as a middleman; outside, he hears the sound of the messages associated with his own past. The parallel perspectives reveal the play's public ethical impact, but do not establish a decisive reformation of the offender. The pane of glass acts as a mirror of self-examination for him, while the ticket window retains the memory of an exploitative market. The setting keeps his private unease and his social history in the same frame.

The Trust's Representative and Ownership of Copies

Batuknath does not attend the performance, but a representative continues making notes about publishing the script and acquiring rights over it. In this small episode the story shows how institutions ready to purchase an artwork may become active as soon as it succeeds. The new names entered by the audience make the representative's seal-based claim to ownership harder to maintain. Yet merely declaring the script “open” cannot automatically settle questions of authorship, family claims or personal rights. Meera will clarify that limit later. The narrative thus distinguishes participation in a shared work from unlimited authority to appropriate it.

Ira's River-Like Metaphor of Authorship

Behind the stage, theatre workers debate whether to print a fixed script or leave room in every performance for local names. Ira's account of authorship as a river gestures away from individual possession and towards a collective flow. A river has many banks, yet its current is not thereby divided: the figure extends the novel's recurrent image of water into the

practice of theatre. Even so, the editorial question remains open. Who may add a local name, with whose permission, and who may refuse its inclusion? The metaphor generates those questions without furnishing a complete institutional procedure for answering them.

Meera's Boundary: A Public Play and Private Testimony

Meera makes clear that even when a play belongs to the public, a person retains authority over public representations of their body, home and suffering. Without her intervention, open authorship might become a new form of exploitation. The right to look, the inheritance of silence and the earlier rules governing the body return here as principles of theatrical ethics. Her intervention interrupts the festival's excitement. That pause is creative rather than obstructive: it keeps dissent and privacy alive inside collective enthusiasm, and prevents the desire for an inclusive public narrative from swallowing the rights of individuals.

A Four-Cornered Pledge in the Dust of the Stage

Ananya draws a small square in the stage dust in place of the circular kabaddi line, creating a space for a new pledge. The image changes from the circle of play and remembrance to the square of public commitment. As the players cross the line, they say "Present," not "kabaddi." This shift in utterance turns an informal theatrical game into an exercise in communal accountability. Had the scene offered only an ethical rejection of applause, it might have remained a sermon. The physical act of crossing a line gives the pledge a bodily form and an observable consequence.

The Videha Flag and a Rediscovery of Meaning

The year and serial number printed on the flag fade in the moonlight, while the word "Videha" remains legible. The children read it not as escape from the body but as a journey back towards bodily dignity. In this way both the play's title and the festival's name acquire new meanings within the story. This remains an interpretation offered by the characters. It should not be quoted as though it were an authoritative definition of an external cultural institution or a settled historical meaning. The narrative creates an internal significance for the word by placing it among embodied acts of remembrance.

Small Footprints and the Uncertainty of Magical Perception

Footprints appear on the empty stage that do not seem to belong to children, actors or elderly spectators. The narrator leaves open the possibility that the dead may have come to see the play, without claiming full external certainty for the event. Its irresolution poetically extends the earlier appearances of the old ghost and Ujjwal's spirit. A reader may

understand the marks in the stage dust as traces of remembrance without asserting that the bodily arrival of invisible persons has been proved. Magical realism retains its force precisely because the account does not force a documentary verdict.

The Final Line That Survives Outside the Script

At daybreak the line "Where the play ends, the village begins" is found written in the dust. Ananya decides to leave it behind rather than insert it into the script. The choice is itself a comment on authorship: some effects cannot be confined within a text but survive as social experience. The chapter goes on to call the earlier "132 acts" seeds. Theatre is thus preparation for social work rather than the point at which that work ends. The concluding line remains outside the written play, allowing the community rather than the script to carry its consequences.

Critical Section 238 | Original Chapter 137 — The Testimony of the Spectators

The Actual Test of Becoming Witnesses Rather Than Spectators

The previous chapters had developed the language of "witnesses, not spectators." In Chapter 137, the formula is tested by the choices of those who were present. Ananya does not immediately open her register; she first wants to see whether the adults can bear the embarrassment of writing about themselves. Narratively this pause is important because the children's ethical authority withdraws for a moment. Testimony begins not through a compulsory act of registration, but through the independent consent of adult characters. The distinction prevents the demand for memory from turning into another demand imposed on those expected to speak.

Auditorium Lights and the Changing Focus on Faces

When the lights come on, people appear absorbed not in evaluating the acting but in questions concerning their own lives. Some cannot bring themselves to look at their phones, while others hold the hand of a stranger sitting nearby. By means of these slight details, the narrator differentiates individual reactions within an apparently shared emotion. Those who watched the same play have not undergone precisely the same psychological transformation. That variety strengthens the scene's credibility and gives human particularity to the collective unity announced from the stage. The spectators remain distinct persons even as their responses intersect.

The Silent Clerk's Yellow List

An elderly man who had worked as a clerk on the bridge project admits that he knew the true number of labourers but stayed silent when a smaller figure entered the official file. The yellow paper he had kept hidden in his pocket for years now opens before the people. The object is more than a token of memory: it provides concrete documentary support for the admission of someone complicit in the wrongdoing. Nevertheless, giving testimony does not complete the legal verification of the facts. The narrative itself presents the action as admitting wrongdoing and restoring names, not as securing a final legal judgement.

The Key to the Medicine Store and Institutional Violence

A woman who distributed medicines recalls that supplies reserved for the poor during the epidemic had been entered under private names. She hands over a small key. The key becomes the visual centre of her testimony, allowing readers to imagine administrative theft as a physical

lock and a storeroom. She also relates the death of her son. Personal grief and culpable silence therefore inhabit the same person. Critical interpretation must not compress these relationships into a simple account of atonement. The ethical difficulty of the scene remains, as loss does not cancel responsibility and confession does not restore the lives affected.

The Advertisement Writer's Crime of Language

A young man who wrote advertisements for digital fraud admits that he did not steal directly, but did compose the words that increased elderly people's fear. His testimony raises the question of participation in violence through language. Respect for names was the play's chief concern; now a maker of words recognises his role in their exploitative use. In this example, narration ceases to be a neutral means of collecting characters. The making and circulation of language become forms of social action, capable of frightening or misleading others even when the writer does not personally take their money.

Minor Wrongdoings and the Crocodile They Form Together

Spectators confess to blocking a marriage, remaining silent while a girl was falsely stigmatised, or turning away after noticing a middleman. These smaller admissions come together as the jaws of a great "crocodile." Rather than locating social violence solely in one gigantic villain, the narrator depicts how the passive participation of numerous ordinary people can produce it. This does not make all the wrongs equal in magnitude. The crocodile as a narrative image reveals their ethical connections; it does not propose identical punishments for every act. The symbol enlarges the scope of accountability without erasing differences of harm.

Batuknath in the Audience: A Reversal of Roles

Batuknath has come to see his theatrical representation. As the spectators' actual testimonies emerge, his legal smile gradually disappears. The man criticised as a character onstage has become a spectator compelled to hear the social effects associated with his conduct. This reversal of roles creates a compelling ethical mirror. Yet Batuknath's silence is not, on its own, complete proof of remorse. Readers must still attend to what he subsequently does. The performance can unsettle a person's established position, but its effect cannot be measured only through an expression or the absence of speech.

Satyavrat's Chair and the Refusal to Be Chief Guest

The organisers invite Satyavrat Mehta to say a few words, but he remains seated on an ordinary chair and listens to the testimony. His posture differs from an exhibition of his former legal status on a public platform.

Remembering his own earlier wrongdoing through silence, he makes the confessions of others a necessary centre of attention. After the inconsistency surrounding his empty chair in the staged play, this account of his actual silence casts a new light on the character's change. The text does not, however, completely reconcile the theatrical and personal levels.

The Actor Becomes the Witness's Attendant

The young kabaddi players, still wearing their theatrical costumes, steady the breathing of those giving testimony, prevent laughter and pause for words caught in tears. This new work of theatre moves the performer away from the position of producing effects and towards the task of protecting another person's opportunity to speak. The real test of acting occurs here: can the actor relinquish centre stage when someone's testimony becomes more important than the play? Through such conduct the rehearsal undertaken in earlier chapters acquires the significance of an actual social practice rather than a mere artistic preparation.

The Double Boundary Between Victim and Perpetrator

Ira observes that the voice of an injured child may sometimes be heard within someone confessing a wrong, and that a victim may feel shame about their own silence. This difficult observation does not mean that victim and perpetrator bear equal blame. Rather, individual histories cannot be fully understood through a single fixed role. Several earlier symbols in the novel had made the form of wrongdoing appear relatively uniform. Ira's observation opens a useful fissure in that simplification. Compassion for a person's history remains distinct from the attribution of responsibility for what they have done.

A New Clause in the Register: Ownership of Testimony

Ananya proposes adding the spectators' testimonies to the next theatrical script. The possibility of collective authorship grows, but so do the risks posed by Chandrapal's sale of emotional data, Raghav's digital network and Broom's funding model. Meera states plainly that testimony belongs to its witness; the stage is that person's servant. The boundary becomes the ethical centre of dramatic composition. An open page may be more inclusive, but cannot consequently be treated as public property without rights or safeguards. The right to tell a story is inseparable from the right to determine its subsequent use.

A Refilled Circle and Differences That Have Not Disappeared

Late at night the auditorium becomes a hybrid of fairground, courtroom and classroom. People write down the names of their silences; a green line shines on the stage's imitation stump, and “Present” circulates in all

directions. The magical sign enlarges the sense of collective experience. Yet bringing actor, offender, victim and spectator into one circle does not abolish their different ethical obligations. The circle images an equal opportunity to remember, not a uniform judgement of fault. The scene should be read as an expansion of voices rather than the sudden dissolution of social distinctions.

Notice of the Next Performance: Practical Conditions for an Open Text

At the festival gate the children announce that spectators' testimony will be incorporated into the next act. No name, however, will be performed without permission, nor will silence be hurried into speech. The announcement clarifies the process of making a new version of the play. Gathering testimony, deciding what to select and staging it will remain separate activities, an important ethical distinction. The play within the story now points to continuous future rewriting: each performance may add new people and perspectives. Its openness depends on those conditions, not simply on the accumulation of more material.

Critical Section 239 | Original Chapter 138 — The Procession Beyond the Stage

When the Auditorium Door Becomes Too Small: An Expansion of Space

After the spectators begin giving testimony, the auditorium doorway becomes too small for the narrative. This image contains the chapter's spatial grammar. The stage's bamboo, earth, stones and the performers' sweat remain inside, while the story goes out on people's shoulders. Its creative significance is that the circulation of a story comes to depend more on relationships among people than on the machinery of performance. The performers no longer occupy the centre. The road, the steps, the tea stall and the bus station become potential locations for new scenes. The widening of space accompanies a widening of narrative agency.

Theatre and Courtroom in Conflict on the Auditorium Steps

People ask whether what they have seen was theatre or a court of law. The narrator preserves an ironic distinction between the two institutions: a court can conceal justice by becoming a performance, while a play can awaken memory by engaging with justice. The reversal derives its force from the earlier chapters concerning Satyavrat, Batuknath and hearings of names. Yet a play cannot actually replace a judicial verdict. In reading the figure, it is essential to distinguish the functions of legal determination from those of a public ethical appeal. The dramatic analogy sharpens the question of justice without settling a case.

The Tea Seller and a New Use for the Credit Ledger

A tea seller who did not attend the play notices the altered faces of the people leaving and asks why they are so silent. A woman mentions her brother, whose name was omitted from the records, and the seller writes it on a page of his credit ledger. This small incident is especially important. A commercial account book, normally used to record debts, becomes a place for testimony about a name. Through the changed purpose of an everyday object, the author shows that a new stage for the story does not require a formal institution. Remembrance enters ordinary exchanges and reshapes what their records can contain.

Ghostly Makeup at the Bus Station and Private Grief

At the bus station, ghostly white makeup still covers an actor's face. He says he will not wash it away before his father's name has been written in full. The artificial colouring of performance becomes a sign of genuine family

remembrance. Travellers start speaking the names of their villages; a transit point is transformed into a place of recollection. Care is required, however, before the artificial makeup is treated as indispensable proof of truth. The paint expresses emotion; it is not a formal historical document. The movement between theatrical artifice and personal grief is meaningful precisely because the two are not identical.

Actors and Characters Converge at the Back Door

As the performers change clothes, they take off the roles of ghosts, drowned people, witches, labourers and middlemen. Behind several of these parts lie actual histories of the neglect suffered by their grandparents. For a moment, the boundary between enacted history and lived history becomes blurred. The narrator does not employ this ambiguity merely for excitement. It reveals the ethical difficulty of assigning a part to an actor: the performer may bear a distinct personal relationship to the figure being portrayed. To act a role is neither to possess another person's experience nor to be wholly detached from it.

The Narrator's Heavy Manuscript: A Changing Weight of Written Text

The narrator of the play counts the sheets; every page is in place, but the manuscript seems unexpectedly heavy. Later, lines resembling the newly offered testimonies appear upon it. This magical-symbolic scene does not mean only that the paper performs a miracle. It is a narrative device for showing how textual meaning changes. The same written dialogue acquires another weight after a public encounter. Through the physical experience of the narrator's palms, the writer questions the conventional one-way model of transmitting a text from its author to an audience. Reception itself becomes a force that alters the manuscript's perceived substance.

A Third Column in the Register: Where Will the Story Go?

On a new page, Ananya writes three prompts: a name, the person for whom one is present, and where the story will travel with the respondent. The third question brings people to a halt, since bearing witness and acting afterwards are different things. Replies concerning home, court, school, falsehoods circulated on phones and a granddaughter's fear of caste mark the story's possible future locations. In this fashion the theatrical narrative turns from a project of historical remembrance into a map of potential actions. The register records not only what has been remembered but the obligations that may follow remembrance.

Printing Versus Permission: An Editorial Tension

Festival managers wish to print the emotionally charged events of the night in the next issue. Meera insists that private testimony must not be published without permission. Here the novel considers its own character as a published work: telling something aloud does not automatically grant the right to print it. The requirement of consent before publication turns the handling of paper into a social responsibility. At the same time, practical procedures for authorial credit and secure recordkeeping remain unclear in so open a text. The episode makes this editorial difficulty visible without pretending that an appeal to openness has already solved it.

The Danger of Digital Trade in Short Scenes

Spectators want to make short videos of different moments in the play, while Devika introduces the rule, “Listen to the whole context.” Chandrapal's application becomes active again in trying to turn emotional scenes into a market. Through this digital repetition the conflict between artistic narrative and platform commerce takes a new form. Previously the theft of material from memory involved names and pictures. Now edited theatrical clips may be used to seize the meaning of a shared experience. A recording that spreads the story may also detach it from the circumstances and permissions that made it possible.

Batuknath's Office and Testimony Beyond Control

A secretary brings news that the play has succeeded, but Batuknath is unsettled less by the number of spectators than by the spread of their testimonies. A crowd can be managed; testimony cannot be completely controlled. This idea stands at the centre of the novel's discussion of power. A senior official may determine permissions, venues or the boundaries of a public event, yet cannot fully govern where an individual voice will tell its story. Batuknath's reaction gives the fear of an institution a concrete office setting. The reported success of an event thus becomes troubling to authority when it produces unanticipated speech.

Kabaddi on the Road: Bringing Theatre to Ground Level

At dawn the performers again play kabaddi in front of the auditorium. A milk carrier, a newspaper distributor, a schoolteacher and a bus conductor become passing spectators. The dust of the stage, the hard earth of the road and the different sound of feet make the change of location material. No winner is announced in the game. At the end, Ananya places earth from the centre line between pages of the register. The soil of play literally becomes a substance associated with writing. The passage transfers theatrical remembrance from a defined arena to the everyday ground where people work and travel.

Admitting the Incompleteness of Publication

What should be printed in the next issue of the Videha Festival: the manuscript, the spectators' testimonies, the rules, or the game played outside? Ira acknowledges that whatever is printed, something will be left out. Her statement recalls the resistance to summary expressed in Original Chapter 133. Selection for performance and selection for publication both necessarily involve omission. Rather than concealing that loss, the text proposes admitting it as a new form of literary modesty. The work publicly recognises the limits of its own representation, even as it seeks to include more speakers and more forms of experience.

Letters from Children Abroad

At the end a postman brings letters from children in distant countries. They too want to perform the play, but promise first to listen to names. The letters extend the story, which began in a domestic kitchen, beyond the sea. Ira's earlier correspondence from abroad provides a causal link for this expansion. Yet no overseas theatrical experiment has occurred at this point. The letters indicate a future possibility, not an accomplished international campaign. To describe them as completed performances would move beyond the events of the original text. The chapter closes on the promise of wider circulation, while leaving its enactment still to come.

Critical Section 240 | Original Chapter 139 — The Road as Theatre

From the Fixed Stage to the Rhythm of a Moving Road

The procession of Chapter 138 becomes a theatrical form occupying public roads in this chapter. On the stage, performers and spectators had assigned places; on the road, the milk seller, vegetable vendor, rickshaw driver and police officer change roles from moment to moment. This mobility expands the narrative's focalisation. Instead of a stable centre, the moment in which a passer-by stops becomes a new scene. The transformation makes the social movement of folk theatre itself into a method of plotting.

Road Time and the Measure of Breath

The kabaddi players practise measuring how many breaths it takes to cross a square, a culvert, a medicine shop and the courthouse veranda. Space is measured not by geographical instruments but by bodily breathing. This extends the earlier rules of kabaddi while changing public movement into a rhythm of private remembrance. The line drawn in the dust by their feet immediately begins to disappear. Narrative space consequently becomes not a permanent monument but a temporary, repeatable event.

The Empty Bowl in the Market and the Opening with One Word

The first performance takes place in the market. Wearing neither ghost masks nor crocodile masks, ordinary young people make a few sounds with an empty bowl and a stone. When the word 'Present' is uttered, a knife cutting fish pauses and an elderly woman selling chillies responds. The market ceases to be a decorated backdrop and becomes a participant. What makes the scene effective is not theatrical splendour but the sudden act of listening amid the labour of earning a living.

At the Bus Stand: Names on Tickets and Nameless Passengers

Leaves distributed to passengers carry the compressed breath, or essential pulse, of earlier chapters. The conductor reads a question about names that do not appear on tickets, turning an ordinary bus journey into a discussion of remembrance. Here a register of names encounters a transport institution. A ticket supplies limited evidence of identity; the narrative asks how many lives fall outside that limitation. Yet the compression into a 'summary-breath' necessarily represents only part of the extensive original story. This limitation must be compared with the author's earlier opposition to summarisation.

The Courthouse Veranda: Silence and Erased Lives

On the courthouse veranda, the players do not shout their performance. They sit down and place a few words and blank sheets of paper before them. Lime falls from an old wall onto an empty page, and its mark is called 'the wall's answer'. Physical decay and institutional remembrance are linked through a magical-symbolic image. Satyavrat decides to listen before writing. Through this restraint the play refrains from prematurely claiming a judicial judgment and instead opens a place in which questions may be asked.

At the Medicine Shop: From Acting to Admission

Outside a medicine shop, the actors create a scene out of breathing and an empty medicine bottle. The shopkeeper first hides indoors, then comes out and admits raising prices during the disaster. The earlier motif of testimony from spectators recurs in a new place. An individual's admission, however, cannot be treated as the complete equivalent of social redress: accusation, verification and compensation are still unresolved. Within that incompleteness the story stages a transition from performance to responsibility.

Administrative Anxiety about the Public Road

Traders fear losing customers, politicians raise the question of permits, and officials warn of inflaming public sentiment. These objections are not necessarily all identical to an exploitative conspiracy; some may concern legitimate public order. Nevertheless, in the original narrative such voices generally appear as restrictions on the public reading of names. The children answer, 'We are not inciting anyone; we are reading names.' The recurrence of this short sentence defines the nonviolent public voice of the play.

Batuknath's Rule File and the Uncertainty of the Road

Hearing of 'theatre on the street', Batuknath searches the rules concerning public thoroughfares, breaches of the peace and permissions. He sees the possibility of stopping a new social experiment through older forms of legal control. Yet the magical appearance of 'Present' upon a blank sheet of paper frustrates his strategy within the narration. The scene offers a powerful satire of institutional fear, although the realistic procedures of an actual legal dispute remain outside its frame. Critical analysis should preserve that distinction.

Chandrapal's Camera and the Danger of Re-Objectification

Chandrapal's associates bring a camera into the market, imagining that the performance can be turned into digital tickets and advertising. Meera

and the other women stop them. Public road theatre is not thereby a space exempt from privacy: those whose lives are recounted must again be asked for their consent. The narrative significance of this recurrence is that taking a work outside does not automatically free it from exploitation. Limits established on the stage must be tested again under the road's new conditions.

Raghav's Division of 'Moving Theatre' into Two Words

Raghav writes 'moving-theatre' in the network, but the message splits into 'moving' and 'theatre'. This magical division of a word depicts the failure of digital control. When people raise their voices without a central leader, account or single director, an old map of wrongdoing becomes ineffective. The incident should not be mistaken for a technical malfunction in an actual information system: the narrator symbolically represents the helplessness of repressive surveillance.

The Rhythm of the Videha Folk Ballad and an Allusion to Salhes

The Salhes folk ballad at the beginning of the chapter sets the rhythm by which a road becomes a theatre. The main prose then translates the song's expansive claim into particular public scenes at the market, bus stand, courthouse and medicine shop. Reference to the folk ballad links the work to Mithila's theatrical traditions, but the narrative is not itself a complete rewriting of Salhes. The movement of folk song and the short pauses within public scenes together create the voice of a 'moving stage'.

The Possibility and Limits of Social Decentralisation

The author suggests that collective speech without a single leader or owner is difficult to control. The idea assumes concrete form in the elderly market woman's answer, the conductor's reading, the medicine seller's admission and the stopping of passers-by. Yet decentralised dialogue also faces difficult questions about protecting evidence, safeguarding privacy and maintaining an organisation over time. These conditions do not disappear because the work envisages a positive possibility. Expanded conversation cannot substitute for institutional accountability.

Letters from Outside and the Road's Future Expansion

The letters received from abroad at the end of the preceding chapter now provide a basis for the road theatre's possible international expansion. Original Chapter 139, however, is chiefly concerned with incidents in the local market, bus stand, courthouse and medicine shop; an actual performance in a distant country is not yet its central event. As the narrative brings these local scenes together, the promise of expansion remains in the future tense. With this restraint, the chapter presents road

theatre not as the conclusion of a completed revolution but as a new social practice of listening.

Inter-sectional Discussion: From the Earth to the Road as Theatre

The fundamental movement of Chapters 132–139 is an extraordinary transformation: from the brief togetherness of a shared plate to a republic of daily labour in the kitchen; from there to an invitation to the theatre, a written dramatic script, a public performance, silence after applause, the testimonies of spectators and finally a theatre that travels along the street. Across these eight chapters one social scene is repeatedly transferred into another medium. Each new medium tests earlier ethical questions against new institutional boundaries rather than resolving them. Inequalities of caste and gender emerge in the kitchen; rights to enact private suffering arise in the theatre; ownership of testimony becomes a problem in print; and regulation of public order enters upon the road.

The sequence's principal material axis consists of used eating vessels, the kitchen cauldron, an unnamed stone, the earth used in performance, a yellow notice, an empty cage, sheets of dramatic writing, the ticket window, the clerk's yellowing list, a key to the medicine store, the tea shop's credit ledger and a slip of paper at the bus stand. These are not merely decorative theatrical properties: each acquires a new function beyond its first social use. A page used to record credit becomes a page for remembering names; the soil of the stage enters the register; and hands that wash vessels challenge a claim to prestige. Such material bridges turn recurrent metaphors into actions within the plot.

The crossing out of 'spectator' and its replacement by 'witness' in the dramatic script may be considered the creative centre of the eight chapters. That single-word revision occurs in Chapter 134. In Chapter 135, people seated around the circular ground call out 'Present'. In Chapter 136, after the performance, they bring forward names that were omitted from their lives. Chapter 137 records their freely offered admissions of wrongdoing, and in Chapters 138–139 different institutions and people in the marketplace participate beyond the stage. The spectator is no longer merely the imaginary audience of the play but a character engaged in making the narrative that follows. Yet through Meera's voice the text repeatedly insists on keeping voluntary testimony, public display and the examination of evidence distinct.

Important questions remain about narrative time and the consistency of the dramatic text. Chapter 133 announces the future order of scriptwriting and performance, Chapter 134 specifies outlines for new scenes, and the performance in Chapter 135 presents several scenes in a changed order. In particular, a nimble child appears in the performance after a quiet player

had been chosen for Batuknath; after a child was assigned Satyavrat's part, the staging includes an empty chair, while a child actor appears again in a later chapter. These are sequential discrepancies. The claim that the earlier 132 instalments had already been acted out on different stages is likewise not clearly differentiated from the immediate process of writing the new play. It would be inappropriate to declare all these difficulties automatically resolved by calling them magical realism. Both the possibility of artistic re-editing and that of textual inconsistency should remain on record.

Chapter 137 is especially important for its plurality of voices. Statements from the bridge clerk, a woman involved in distributing medicines, a young man who wrote the language of fraud and ordinary people who took part in caste-based restrictions reveal several levels of social wrongdoing. Victimhood and remembrance of wrongdoing can sometimes coexist within one person; the narrative thereby challenges a simplified division between hero and villain. Testimony itself, however, is not a final determination of verified fact. In the writer's communal language it marks the beginning of acknowledgement. Allowing spectators to participate in writing is valuable, but each new testimony still requires permission to publish, protection of the person's dignity and attention to historical context.

The final two chapters refuse to keep the theatrical perimeter fixed. The tea stall, bus stand, market, courthouse veranda and medicine shop become possible stages. In this new geography the players are not necessarily performers: they mediate listening among otherwise unnamed people on the road. Even so, the main narrative only anticipates performances by children abroad; it does not establish that they have already happened. Ira's acknowledgement that publication necessarily leaves something out, Meera's protection of private testimony and Ananya's practice of leaving room for every new name define the self-imposed limits of the moving story.

Thus the conclusion of Critical Sections 233–240 is not a claim that full justice has been established, but a new condition governing the relation between acting and living. After the communal meal, vessels still had to be washed; after a performance, labour and courage are still needed in spectators' lives. Where the story had said that applause marked the end of a performance, the next chapter sets actual applause against the effort to stop it. Such a discordant emotional beat reveals, within the novel's long structure, an unstable relationship between the effects of narration and the residue of events. The kabaddi line travels from the stage to the road: it holds open the possibility of another chapter without declaring all earlier suffering resolved.

Critical Section 241 | Original Chapter 140 — The Moving Chaupal

From Moving Theatre to an Assembly without a Fixed Place

In the preceding chapter the performance spread into the market, the bus stand and the courthouse veranda. Chapter 140 names this mobility the 'moving chaupal' and establishes practical rules for it. An open space, ears willing to listen and an incomplete name: these three things take the place of a stage. The reduction is not merely the consequence of scarce resources. It changes the distribution of power in the plot. At the theatre, a spectator came forward; in the chaupal, a listener brings a new story into being. Once the permanence of a site disappears, the performance becomes a continuing journey of testimony from one place to another.

Kabaddi without Victory or Defeat: A Changed Purpose for the Game

The players decide to hold a kabaddi game after each performance, but without declaring either a winner or a loser. Crossing a boundary, hearing one name and returning before the breath gives out now privilege the ability to listen over the result of a competition. The rhythm of the traditional contest survives, but its meaning changes. The boundary line is shown as comparable to the margin of a legal document, the ridge of a field and the cover of a file. The reader understands that, for a person whose name has been 'cancelled', the social game has already predetermined defeat.

The Old Ghost's Formula: 'It Must Be Played, Not Merely Read'

An earlier statement by the old ghost is heard again at the opening of the chapter. The return is the narrator's means of recalling preceding events and clarifying the purpose of the new situation. Reading names began as a written record, acquired a voice in the theatre and now becomes a bodily technique through play. The game is therefore more than a metaphor for instruction: performers must struggle to sustain their breath, while listeners gain an opportunity to respond by naming them. Nevertheless, a successful game does not conclude an actual lawsuit. The narrative is still preparing to move toward an institutional stage.

The Narrator's Double Image of the Road

The opening narration calls the road the oldest theatre of all, yet subsequent scenes make that same road a target of institutional regulation. People move on one side, while the administration seeks to measure their steps through the language of obstruction. By saying that footsteps can be measured but the road cannot, the narrator distinguishes an individual

body from collective remembrance. Repeating the image does not make freedom on the road an easy victory, for a police notice arrives almost immediately. An optimistic expansion in language remains in tension with the legal restrictions introduced by events.

The Writing of a Child Seeing the Performance for the First Time

When Ananya writes in the register that the story has returned from learning on the road, a child who has seen the performance for the first time adds an interpretation beneath her sentence. This small incident cracks open the monopoly of authorship. The child is not only a follower but a co-interpreter who writes his own sentence about what has occurred. His formulation, that life should be made to tell its own lies, turns the aim of theatre away from stage imitation and toward social exposure. But the child's sentence is a critical proposition, not a verified historical finding; the narrator does not instantly transform it into a verdict of popular justice.

Evening Exhaustion and the Domestic Turn of the Assembly

The procession returns at dusk, and the performers are tired. Rest calms the excessive excitation of acting. Feet returning to the stump in the grove reconnect the narrative with its earlier local centre. Experience gained on the road is condensed into one line of the register, yet the same line opens the next development. Ba's question—now it is life's turn—imagines an extension of theatre into the home, kitchen, office and even sleep. These are possibilities still to be enacted; criticism should not treat them all as experiences already completed.

A Folded Paper from the Police Station: The Entry of Legal Obstruction

Two constables arrive on bicycles and courteously hand over a folded notice. It demands an explanation of 'unauthorised obstruction of a road' and 'performance-like activity'. The drama of its arrival lies in the mildness of the delivery: no one shouts and no one is arrested, but the administration has begun to confine the story within its own definitions. Instead of inventing a sensational newspaper report or a scene of violent repression, the author begins the coming struggle with a small sheet of paper. This understated portrayal of institutional action turns the course of the long narrative.

The Yellow Notice Remembered in a New Administrative Order

Ananya puts the police notice in the same place where the earlier yellow government notice had been kept. Reusing the location returns the reader to the memory of dispossession and disputes over property. The edge of the

stump ceases to be an ordinary tabletop: through the papers repeatedly placed there, it becomes a common stage for institutional directives and the community's counter-questions. The earlier notice and the present accusation of obstructing a road, however, do not constitute an identical legal procedure. The recurrence is imagistic, not proof of factual identity. That distinction matters to the critical reading.

Satyavrat's Deferred Reply and a Pause for Breath

From a distance Satyavrat Mehta says the notice will be read tomorrow. This brief statement determines the chapter's closing direction. Instead of immediately interpreting the rules, he suspends narrative time for one night. The pause differs from the protracted postponements of previous lawsuits, because here delay is presented as a period in which the people can prepare. Yet 'tomorrow' carries sharp irony: in this novel, the court's tomorrows have consumed years. The narrative must now discover how humane this new tomorrow will prove to be.

Kabaddi Played with Paper: From Metaphor to Procedural Plot

The final words of the chapter anticipate a 'kabaddi of papers'. Until now, bodies holding their breath and crossing lines have faced the metaphorical presences of cheats, ghosts and crocodiles. In the next chapter, lines of regulations themselves will become boundaries. Thus the novel continually tests one symbol in new institutions. The technical advantage is that distinct episodes in a very long narrative are connected into a series. The danger is that repetition may erase the distinctions between actual files and actual people. Here the notice's specific terminology protects the story against that risk.

A Plurality of Voices and an Incomplete Conclusion

The old ghost, Ba, Ananya, a child newly arrived as spectator, the constables and Satyavrat each perform a different function. The old ghost speaks in a folk voice of principle; Ba points to a future direction; Ananya keeps the record; the child adds interpretation; the police provide institutional classification; and Satyavrat determines when an answer will be attempted. This differentiation creates the chapter's collectivity. No legal decision has been reached at the end. Only the language of the notice has become an object of public hearing. Acknowledging this limit makes the forthcoming narrative more credible.

Critical Section 242 | Original Chapter 141 — The Verdict of the Veranda

The Courthouse Threshold: A Condition between Inside and Outside

The courthouse veranda assumes a presence almost like that of the chapter's principal character. The narrator calls it not simply part of a building but 'a state between inside and outside'. A litigant cannot obtain justice within the court, yet cannot abandon the case and go home; consequently, that person is held permanently upon the threshold of waiting. Personification of the place makes an institutional deprivation of justice felt by the reader. The veranda's stones accumulate voices while enduring the pressure of shoes. This magical-realist image condenses the unheard voices of waiting people; it is not an official judicial record.

A Twenty-Three-Year Lawsuit: The Bodily Cost of Time

An elderly litigant says his case has lasted twenty-three years. That concrete duration prevents 'the next date' from remaining an abstract administrative expression; it becomes an experience distributed across family life. The son's youth, the father's eyesight, the daughter's education and the years in which her marriage might have taken place are all hidden behind successive slips of paper. The narrator associates lost time with a crocodile eating the body. The judicial problem therefore generates pathos not merely through hearing procedures but through the unequal pace of narrative time and lived time. The old man's actual verdict remains pending—a limit that must be repeatedly recognised.

The Question after the Performance and the Collapse of Theatre's Boundary

The performance on the veranda is over and the actors are removing their costumes when the elderly litigant asks who will write down the documents of his life. This incident defeats the convention that a play has ended. An unplanned listener's voice emerges from an imagined dialogue, and the performers stand still. The novel reworks the motif of spectators' testimony from Chapter 137 in the setting of a court. The old man's account nevertheless concerns one particular life. The story does not claim that a judicial order has automatically come into existence through the impact of theatre.

The Clerk's Keys and the Fear of Losing His Job

A clerk emerging from the record room initially fears breaching discipline. Hearing the old man's question, however, changes the

significance of the rattling keys. An instrument for opening a room becomes a symbol of a silenced throat. Before asking his name, Ananya asks him to name his fear, and the answer is 'the fear of losing my job'. The character is therefore not a simple villain: he carries institutional anxiety, although that anxiety does not abolish his responsibility for keeping silent. The symbolic object and the complexity of character reinforce each other.

An Old Advocate's Coat: Removing the Cover of a Profession

A former pupil of Batuknath lays his black advocate's coat on the stone veranda. Taking off the garment is no immediate proof of moral purification, but it is a public attempt to emerge from behind a professional identity. Slips recording court dates fall from the pockets, exposing a fundamental violence in the language of litigation. The children do not pick them up at once; they want every date to be read together with the experience it conceals. The hesitation changes the sense of ownership: the advocate may become an accountable reader of the slips rather than their controller.

Reading the Dates: Family Lives Instead of Calendar Entries

Each date is connected with the auction of land, medical treatment, interrupted education or a cooking hearth left cold. This interwoven series forms an important technique of archival narration. In the original court list a date announced only the next hearing. The children add the human loss incurred on that day. By rewriting the entries, the old gaps in the case acquire new density as narrated events. Yet this does not mean every slip has already been verified. The episode begins a 'reading of dates', not a final judgment upon evidence.

Devika's Turn from Performance to Reading

Devika says that theatre has taken place on this veranda and now it is time to read. Her sentence provides a second turn in the chapter. Acting awakens sympathy; reading requires the repeated labour of listening, checking mistakes and searching for the people behind dates. The children write dates and accompanying names on the stone. Writing upon stone offers a small alternative between formal written litigation and the oral tradition of speaking names. It has not become a separate courtroom; rather, people are practising a language in which to describe their waiting.

Meera's Resistance: Privacy against a Successful Public Performance

Young people carrying cameras advance toward the scene, but Meera forbids the public exhibition of suffering without permission. The right acquired by spectators who became witnesses in the preceding theatrical chapters is limited here: seeing, hearing and publishing are three different

acts. This resistance constitutes a moment of self-criticism within the novel, because enthusiasm for popular justice may also violate the privacy of the injured. Even as she stands for social justice, Meera recognises the danger of a violence committed in the name of performance.

The Return of the Actors from the False-Ghost Procession

The actors of the earlier procession of false ghosts arrive on the veranda and recognise that their former performance was commissioned for payment, whereas the unresolved story contained in the papers now pursues them like a real ghost. Their return preserves the novel's long-term memory of its characters. What had once provided an instrument of deception and spectacle becomes material for the actors' own ethical transformation. The fleeting shadow of the old ghost echoes the thought; it should not be mistaken for an actual, documented appearance in a court of law.

Satyavrat's Old Page: The Veranda as the Court's Unhearing Ear

After midnight Satyavrat removes a sheet from his pocket and gives it to Ananya. It describes the veranda as the court's ear that has failed to listen. Through this act an individual legal professional's testimony enters a child's communal record. The significance is not that Satyavrat has pronounced a new judgment: he admits a failure to hear and supplies the metaphor of an ear. Ananya adds a complementary line: if the ear opens, the veranda will become a court. This is a condition for the future, not an achievement already established.

The Rustling Record Room: Foreshadowing the Next Chapter

The narrative ends with suggestions that old files in the record room stir of their own accord and that dust forms letters. It is a dramatic anticipation in magical-realist form, not a report that judicial records have materially changed their condition. Public voices on the veranda are depicted as capable of awakening documents shut away inside. The spatial movement is clear: from the road to the veranda, and from the veranda to the record room. Through this succession, the following chapter opens not as an unrelated episode but as the material layer of a question already raised.

Critical Section 243 | Original Chapter 142 — The Darkness of the Record Room

Time Imprisoned in a Cupboard: An Architectural Image of Duration

At the beginning of Chapter 142, a cupboard is called a little dark house. Outside it, seasons, harvests, children's ages and family lives continue to change, while the days held inside its files remain still. This stillness is named not peace but decay. The contrast between temporal orders makes the physical site of the archive a major element of the narrative's structure. In Satyavrat's perception the record room becomes the 'stomach' of the court. Whether its papers will become decisions or oblivion is the question that carries witnesses from the road into the inner darkness of the cupboard.

Bhikhari Lal's Lock and the Breathing Inside

As the attendant Bhikhari Lal opens the latch, he says that the lock is not old: it is the breathing inside that has grown heavy. His statement turns an inanimate office building into an image of living expectation. A man previously perceived as a subordinate worker whose task was to clear dust becomes the most sensitive observer of the archive's decaying time. In narrative terms, the next mediator guarding names is not a senior official but the person who unlocks the room. Bhikhari Lal's language arises out of experience and feeling; it should not be treated as a scientific account of a physical examination of the cupboard.

The Smell of Dust: An Archive Beyond Sight

When the door opens, the smells of rotting glue, dampness, ink, sweat and waiting rise together. Through the experience of smell, the narrator gives the reader access to the historical burden of old papers. Dust is not merely dirt here; it becomes a remnant of names that have not been heard. Yet the use of dust as a metaphor does not cause the actual writing on the papers to be neglected. Ananya and Meera establish rules for preventing tears, counting the leaves and reading them slowly. Sensory magical realism and careful examination of documents proceed together in the same scene.

A Fragment of a Wedding Invitation: Social Damage within a Lawsuit

Inside a file concerning a land dispute lies a torn fragment of a wedding invitation. The official heading concerns land, but the breakdown of a marriage in a family survives in a corner of the paper. Through this contrast, the storyteller opens a gap between the declared subject of an archive and the indirect consequences for human lives. The small invitation is an 'object witness' within the narrative: it helps the reader

grasp how a lawsuit consumes social time as well. Nevertheless, the fragment cannot by itself determine the legal merits of the entire dispute; it points toward a relationship that has gone unheard.

Five Stamps Marked 'Received' and No Reply

Another file bears the stamp 'Received' on five applications but contains not a single reply. The repetition reveals the frightening emptiness of administrative action. Acceptance of the paper constitutes only a formal achievement; neither a hearing nor a resolution has followed. Bhikhari Lal's memory of the instruction 'Come tomorrow' connects the file to human time. The twenty-three-year lawsuit in Chapter 141 is here divided into numerous smaller postponements. The effect arises not from a dramatic slogan but from the unequal count of stamps and absent orders.

The Red-Thread File and a Student Whose Name Was Altered

Behind a third cupboard a file tied with red thread contains a complaint about the alteration of a young man's surname in an admission register, endangering his identification for a scholarship and employment. The red thread has an imagistic connection with an earlier scene involving a bird's beak. The text does not, however, offer decisive proof that the thread in the two incidents is one and the same physical object. Its narrative power lies in showing how a tiny change in spelling may close many doors in a life. A name here is not an aesthetic ornament but an institutional key to education and work.

An Elderly Woman's Missing Husband's File: A Search That Repeatedly Fails

An elderly woman who has waited throughout the night searches for papers concerning her husband. Differences in years, numbers and versions of the name repeatedly frustrate the search. When a sack is overturned for the fifth time, half a name is discovered. The sequence gives the story the pace of an investigation, distinct from emotional testimony alone. Her assertion that even half a name is a name if someone will listen to it in full turns an archival deficiency into a human possibility. Yet finding half the name is not recovery of the complete file. The author does not erase that incompleteness.

'A Missing File Does Not Mean a Person Has Ceased to Exist': A New Register

Devika proposes compiling a list of missing files alongside a separate register of oral testimony. At this moment a new narrative rule emerges: the imperfection of material records cannot cancel a person's identity. The clerk's offering of a pencil and the hesitant opening of a new register mark

the change through small actions. On the imaginative plane, files become alive; on the practical plane, lists, copies and family statements remain subject to examination. The double procedure keeps the chapter from becoming merely a miraculous metaphor about documents.

An Advocate's Labour and the Limits of Forgiveness

Batuknath's former pupil tries to apologise, but Meera tells him to undertake the actual work of finding files. Wrongdoing committed in a professional capacity cannot be forgiven through a single public speech. This theme connects with Batuknath's own belated apology in an earlier chapter. The young man lifts papers without taking a fee, and dust settles on his hands. The materiality of the action becomes a test of ethical improvement. Even so, moving a few files cannot be considered an erasure of earlier failures of justice.

Satyavrat's Order and the Question of Institutional Authority

At the close of the chapter, Satyavrat writes a short order calling for every file to be counted again, a public list of missing files, and a temporary record of oral testimony. Within the narrative, this is a definite procedural change: previous scenes centred on communal reading and individual admissions. But the text has not yet demonstrated the legal authority of this order, its actual implementation, or an outcome in another court. The distinction is essential for criticism: an order written in a literary episode must not be equated with a completed reform of judicial administration.

From Darkness toward the Sack of Discarded Papers

Even after several cupboards in the record room have been opened, one corner remains occupied by a sack of discarded papers. Ananya had noticed that corner at the beginning, giving the next chapter an anticipated setting. From accumulated darkness the narrative turns toward the things society has thrown away. The writer's device is to reverse the hierarchy of objects: the least respected rubbish may contain the most consequential remnant. The mood is not one of celebration but of caution. The children withhold their applause, because the work has only begun.

Critical Section 244 | Original Chapter 143 — The Testimony of the Discarded Sack

Rereading Discarded Pages and the Elevation of an Object

Here the narrative enters the sack labelled as waste in the court's record room. In the official classification, the files were 'incomplete', 'unavailable' or 'unclear'; the children, however, read them as potential sources of social testimony. The passage from 'waste' to 'human testimony' is the chapter's fundamental transformation of an object's standing. Discarded paper acquires the possibility of being planted like a seed. This metaphor connects the episode with the earlier chapter on guarding seeds, but it does not eliminate the need for archival verification.

The Thumbprint and the Reversal of the Charge of Illegibility

On one sheet, a widow's trembling handwriting has been marked 'unclear' in red ink. The narrator asks what is unclear: the hand marked by suffering, or the eyes unwilling to read it? The reversal exposes the social power exercised through writing. A thumbprint is a personal trace of the body, yet the office can readily declare it invalid. The legibility of a document becomes a matter not merely of beautiful letters but of the reader's social preparedness. Nor does criticism require every blurred document to be accepted as correct: the story still calls for a separate, careful procedure of corroboration.

'Hear Me': The Sentence That Survives Before the Name

Only the words 'Hear me' and a thumbprint remain on one fragile sheet; the name and address are incomplete. Rather than discard the sentence because the name cannot be recovered, Ananya decides to preserve it. This is a significant linguistic invention in the narrative: the absence of an identifiable person does not extinguish the residual right to speak. An ordinary first-person plea becomes the possible presence of an entirely unknown human being. Yet the narrator does not attach it to a fabricated, particular deceased person, instead keeping its place open. This refusal of an unwarranted specificity matters for criticism.

Bhikhari Lal's Broom: Reversing the Violence of Cleaning

Bhikhari Lal sets his broom against the wall and admits that, while clearing dust, he may also have swept away the testimony borne by many papers. The old meaning of his occupational labour changes at this moment. A broom had been an instrument of cleaning; the story reveals its possible role in unwitting erasure. Bhikhari Lal is not himself a senior official, and it would be unjust to make his remorse bear the entire

institution's responsibility. His admission, the clerk's conduct and orders from above remain distinct levels in the narrative.

The Lost Footpath: Erasure from a Map and the Severing of Relations

A family file contains two brothers, a sister, a pond's edge and a footpath that disappeared in an official survey. When the path vanished from the paper, the sister's route to her parental home also disappeared. This account connects physical geography with kinship. A girl named Neelima draws the footpath on a separate sheet. Her line is not a substitute for an authorised map but a question raised from memory. Through this small drawing, however, the woman's right of passage acquires a new centrality in the story.

Lau's File and the Authority of the Word 'Irrelevant'

An old letter suggests that certain records had deliberately been declared irrelevant, bringing the possibility of a plan into view alongside mere negligence. Devika asks how a document can be irrelevant when somebody's life has been transformed by it. The narrator exposes the administrative cruelty embedded in that word. But the letter does not establish an entire conspiracy: its source, chain of orders and connections remain to be investigated. That distinction is essential to the inquiry that follows within the novel.

Copies and the Shared Discipline of Privacy

The group agrees that every surviving page should be copied, but Meera insists that names whose disclosure might harm families must not be made public without permission. A tension emerges between archival transparency and personal dignity. Saving a paper is not the same as laying open a person's life. The narrative itself guards this distinction, which may be described in criticism as archival ethics. Publishing everything is not synonymous with truth: oral context and individual rights must also be protected.

'It Looks Like': The Difference Between Resemblance and Confirmation

An elderly litigant says one sheet looks like an application submitted by his brother. Meera immediately explains that resemblance is the beginning of testimony, not its final confirmation. This is among the chapter's most valuable moments of self-correction. The novel repeatedly introduces magical signs, smells and intimate memories, yet here it separates emotional urgency from concrete documentary comparison. The scene shows that respect for grief and refusal to impose a false certainty can coexist.

Living and Dead Files: The Metaphorical Humanity of an Archive

The children sort files into those that are living, dead, half-dead, liable to be stolen or in need of cautious handling. These are not official legal categories but an emotional, communal ordering. A file is 'living' when someone still breathes while awaiting its decision. By linking the condition of objects to the condition of people, the narrator gradually develops the archive itself almost as a character within the long narrative. This classification has emotional force; nevertheless, the actual state of each document and the legal procedure require separate examination.

The Empty Sack: A Warning, Not a Museum Piece

After the sheets have been removed, the empty sack is turned inside out and marked as the place where testimony had been suppressed. Devika makes clear that it will survive as a warning, not as an ornamental museum object. The decision recalls the earlier danger of turning memory into a commodity. The object becomes a symbol of vigilance, while profitable display and veneration are resisted. The story does not seek to appropriate the old object but to remember the social failure it embodies.

The Structural Inconsistency of a Repeated Ending

In the original chapter, a conclusion in which the waste sack is emptied, night falls and Ananya's register remains open is followed by a second, conclusion-like sequence: 'night descended' again, the record room closed, and a copy was read to the elderly litigant. This may be a magical circularity of time or an editorial repetition; the text does not clearly establish that the episodes take place on different nights. It would therefore be unwarranted to pronounce the inconsistency a definite artistic design. Both endings nevertheless share the idea of the human beings inside the papers coming out into view, preparing the image of the journey of names.

From the Page to the Threshold

Once the papers from the sack are brought into the veranda, the absence of the families and the need to return their names become urgent. Testimony can no longer remain enclosed within the record room: it must be connected to people in their homes. The next chapter, 'The Journey of Names', takes up that unfinished task. Narrative continuity arises not from an artificial mystery but from a practical deficiency: the names have survived, but the people or their families have not yet been reached. The metaphor of discarded paper thereby turns towards concrete social action.

Critical Section 245 | Original Chapter 144 — The Journey of Names

From the Cupboard to the Threshold: The Material Displacement of Names

Names preserved in the 'record room' and the 'waste sack' now travel across stones, steps, gates and village roads. The narrator personifies letters as though names had left their files and set off to find their own homes. At the level of actual events, however, the children compile lists, match old addresses and search for relatives. This double narration is a principal device of the book's magical realism: the independent journey of letters is a sensory metaphor, while the movement of the human group is social labour. The two planes transform one another without collapsing into one.

Three Groups of Names and an Order of Absence

The names are divided into three groups: living people whose permission can be sought, deceased people whose relatives must be located, and those whose homes, lineages or whereabouts have become obscure. Memory thus becomes an arrangement for making contact, not merely a record. The decision to give the third group a place beneath the shade of the Channa grove is important, for the narrative does not invent a happy ending in which every name finds a home. Even those for whom no threshold can be found must have a place. This condition preserves the reality of enduring grief.

Meera and Devika's Slow Steps: An Ethics of the Pace of Testimony

Meera and Devika establish rules for carrying news of the names to people's homes: no crowd is to gather, and visitors should approach each doorway quietly. A story that succeeded on stage in the voice of a crowd must lower its voice before entering a home. Through this change in sound, the narrative demonstrates a restraint suited to the situation. A private courtyard of mourning is not an extension of the theatre; it is another sphere of rights. Reading a name with permission restores its human presence, whereas an announcement without permission can become another spectacle.

From a Land-Register Number to a Boatman's Memory: Constructing a Route

Half the village name in Jasoda Devi's file has been erased, but the account number for her field survives. Bhikhari Lal recalls an auction paper; the

elderly litigant describes the old market and the path near a peepal tree; a boatman remembers a woman who used to sit on a field boundary. The search route is formed by bringing these small clues together. The writer does not allow a single character to understand everything through omniscience. Instead, official documents, local geographical knowledge and direct witnesses jointly help the characters move forward. The narrator's polyphonic method becomes part of the actual sequence of events.

Crossing the River: Beyond the Boundaries of Paper into the Terrain of Life

On the way to Jasoda's village, the narrative describes a half-paved road, an old collapsed bridge, an eroded bank and the smell of the wet bottom of the boat. Without this physical journey, 'returning a name home' would remain merely a moral exhortation. The labour of crossing the river measures narrative distance: in the court file, the name occupied a single line; reaching its home requires a river crossing, fatigue and knowledge of an older landscape. The water associated earlier with burial among crocodiles is here not merely an object of fear but the difficult passage by which a lost relationship may be restored.

Jasoda Herself Is Absent; Her Niece Bears Witness

The searchers do not find Jasoda Devi alive. At her doorway stands her niece, now a grandmother herself. This generational delay corresponds to the damage inflicted by the 'twenty-three years' invoked at the beginning. On hearing the name, the niece asks whether that name is still alive. Her question sharply exposes the distance between the administrative list and family remembrance. The story does not bring Jasoda back as a living character; it brings her name back into the voice of a relative. The distinction between living memory and a living person must be maintained.

The Occupying Party's Response and the Limits of Accusation

A small brick warehouse now stands on Jasoda's former field. Its caretaker asks what purpose can be served by reopening an old case. Bhikhari Lal recalls the consequences of a document passing into the wrong hands. Devika, however, does not immediately write an accusation against the man; she records only that the occupying party tried to evade the question. This self-imposed limit is decisive from a critical perspective. Village anger and documentary history exist within the story, but a definite charge is not declared without further evidence. Such restraint makes the characters' ethical labour credible.

Refusing to Carry Away the Soil: Resistance to Exploiting the Scene

The group takes no photographs at Jasoda's home or former field, and does not even remove a little soil. With the family's consent, it records oral memories instead. This unusual restraint is significant. In several earlier chapters, touching a grove, pond or dust had been a chief vehicle of remembrance; here touching itself is restricted. An object charged with a victim's associations cannot always justly be taken away. The change amounts to a critical safeguard imposed by the narrative upon the intentions of community-based research.

The Clerk's Limited Public Authority

The clerk states that copies of every private file cannot be supplied, although a list of public records can be prepared. The journey of names thereby acknowledges institutional limits. The desire for people's justice does not automatically turn every government record into unrestricted public property. Devika recognises the statement as an appropriate use of the language of rights. The narrative does not always portray procedure as an enemy: where procedure protects individuals and privacy, it can be useful to collective work.

The Possibility of Three Copies and a Double Vigil

One group goes to the homes, Ananya and Meera remain at the court to care for the lists, and Satyavrat attends to security in the record room. This distribution of locations prevents the plot from becoming the expedition of a solitary hero. Obtaining testimony at home, preserving documentary integrity at court, and respecting the limits on publication occur at the same time. The writer shows the interdependence of several sites. Reading them as entirely independent sequences occurring at separate times would obscure the connections that hold the story together.

The Journey's Achievement and the Postponement of Real Resolution

By the day's end, the niece's consent, her oral statement and a note on the field's present condition have returned to court. This marks the beginning of the file's social completion; the chapter does not show a restoration of land ownership, the award of compensation or a judicial order. Ananya's declaration that this is 'not a dead case' is a linguistic affirmation of memory's revival. This precise limit is essential to the long narrative's credibility: travelling towards justice and securing justice are two different stages.

Foreshadowing the Fear to Come

As names begin to reach their homes, the system that suppressed their papers starts to lose the protection afforded by darkness. The chapter's closing indication leads into 'The First Crack in Fear'. The narrator opens a new phase of external conflict: the struggle is now directed not only against the victims' absence but also against the apprehension of those who benefited from that absence. The quiet utterance of a name in an individual's home becomes a public threat to a criminal network. This reversal generates the scenes that follow.

Critical Section 246 | Original Chapter 145 — The First Crack in Fear

The Changing Centre of Fear Within the Accused Powers

Once the names from the record room have been made into a list, the narrator turns towards the rooms occupied by the parties implicated in wrongdoing. Chandrapal's teacup trembles; Raghav's laughter stops midway; Lau examines a slip bearing his old signature; Batuknath's heirs use portraits and deeds of donation to protect their reputation. One event produces the same broad emotion in many places, though its language differs. This parallel sequence constructs a social geography of fear. The story presents the system of wrongdoing not as a single monster but as a collection of interconnected interests.

The Gradual Formation of a 'Crack' and the Rejection of Instant Victory

The title suggests that fear does not break all at once: a fine crack appears first. The narrator translates that metaphor into events. Three separate copies of the people's names now circulate, but the court has issued no final judgment, nor has the network been entirely destroyed. Fear first becomes unstable because none of the parties can any longer regard the documents as lifeless things. This incomplete condition must be understood as the outcome of the episode, not as a complete triumph of justice.

Different Grammars of Fear in Different Houses

The same news becomes economic insecurity for Chandrapal, failure of a network for Raghav, anxiety over forged signatures for Lau, and a crisis of reputation for the heirs. The narrator's presentation of multiple languages for a single cause accords with the novel's many-character structure. In particular, the mention that Batuknath himself is absent from the mansion calls for comparison with his differing states of presence in earlier chapters. This might distinguish a name's social authority from the body's absence; but the continuous time and place of the events are not fully clear, so criticism retains the matter as a question.

Three Copies: The Distributed Security of the Paper's Body

The statement that copies of the names are kept in three places—the record room, the veranda and Ananya's group—is central to the altered pattern of fear. A document stored in one cupboard could be destroyed; when it exists in several places, control becomes more difficult. The narrative arrangement gives the reader a cause for Chandrapal's associates'

apprehension. Yet the multiplication of copies does not itself guarantee factual accuracy. Further scrutiny, comparison with sources and permission remain necessary. This distinction between physical security and evidentiary reliability prepares the next crisis.

The Clerk's 'Statement of an Employee's Silence'

An official reprimands the clerk for showing files without permission, but the clerk takes out a small slip and decides to testify about his own silence. Here the first real crack in fear occurs at the level of an individual. The clerk admits the earlier silence that the darkness of the record room had sheltered until now. By contrasting his trembling hand with his steady voice, the narrator portrays courage without turning him into an exaggerated hero. His risk is real, and his statement is not the disposal of the case but the opening of another avenue of investigation.

Bhikhari Lal's Transformation: From Broom to Statement

Bhikhari Lal, the office attendant, acknowledges his habit of calling old papers rubbish. This modest admission is a direct consequence of the earlier chapter on the discarded sack. The words 'They were not rubbish', spoken by a character holding a low position in the court, acquire public moral weight. The story does not make him answerable for every wrong, but it requires him to recognise his unwitting participation. The worker's ethical development arises not from official rank but from his capacity to understand the significance of his own labour anew.

Satyavrat and the Official: A Dispute over Procedure

An official claims that the procedure is being obstructed; Satyavrat replies that the human beings belonging to the procedure are being returned to it. The novel's long-standing tension between 'law' and 'justice' enters a new situation in this exchange. Satyavrat is no longer merely a character burdened by guilt; he takes part in reading people's names and questioning opaque institutional conduct. The dialogue nevertheless is not a definitive legal ruling, only a moment in the struggle over authority within a local office. Recognising that limit establishes the proper scale of the narrative achievement.

Testimony Across Generations: The Elderly Litigant and His Grandson

A slip bearing an elderly litigant's name reaches his grandson, who asks whether the name is indeed his grandfather's. The old man's answer transforms the lawsuit from a dispute merely about land into a story of a family's waiting. The stagnant time of a file enters the living memory of a later generation. The reader sees the enduring effect of a court date within

one home, while the parallel depiction of the wrongdoers' fear gains a concrete human cause.

The Crocodile of Rumour and the Discipline of Facts

Stories spread through the village of a ghost court, children reading curses, the clerk possibly losing his job, and news appearing in print. The narrator calls rumour a 'crocodile hungry for ears'. This extends the novel's central image: the crocodile is no longer only a creature of water but an appetite for unverified speech. Aruni writes down a rule against explaining signs in haste. Because of this caution, the narrative does not automatically present its magical occurrences as externally established facts; it distinguishes what has happened from the interpretations circulating among people.

The Secret Meeting and an Elderly Advocate's Dissent

Chandrapal, Raghav's adviser, Batuknath's representative and a group of lawyers consider whether to declare the list illegal or pressure the clerk. In the midst of the discussion, an elderly advocate asks where they will imprison the names if they change the locks. As the question comes from within the network itself, it offers the clearest event-based confirmation of the title 'The First Crack in Fear'. A single remark by the elder does not, however, mean that the network has collapsed; it is the first difference in a previously shared strategic confidence.

Fear's Bodily Forms and Its Narrative Contagion

A trembling cup, a drying throat, a fading smile, a key held motionless and the cold air of a meeting translate fear from an abstract idea into bodily sensation through small actions and objects. Each character's face, together with the vocabulary of that person's work, produces a different image of anxiety. As the list of names travels in new copies, fear itself assumes changing forms, like a boat, fire or crack. The sequence displays the writer's skill in parallel montage: not the repetition of one statement, but the presentation of an event's effects in many directions.

The Necessary Movement Towards the Stain of the Seal

The possibility of changing locks, the proposal to invalidate the names and the central role of documents in the secret meeting make the following chapter necessary. To understand the source of fear, one must now examine the file's red seal, its date and the hand that wielded it. The chapter thus moves beyond the psychological texture of apprehension towards a concrete archival mark. In critical terms, the verbal metaphor of the first crack and the material stain of the seal form successive steps in a single inquiry.

Critical Section 247 | Original Chapter 146 — The Stain of the Seal

The Circular Mark of Ink: The Institution's Bodily Signature

Chapter 146 turns the seal from a lifeless circular shape into a stain on the human body. A family's life changes as soon as an application is marked 'verified' or 'rejected'; the object's significance therefore goes far beyond the craft of applying ink. The narrator depicts a contest between the seal's circle and the lines of a thumbprint. A human being has supplied a trace of the body, only to have that trace overwhelmed by the sign imposed by an office above. This image condenses the power relations of the whole documentary system onto one page.

The Babool Boundary and the Line in the Survey Register

In the first file, the boundary of a field had been marked by a babool tree planted by the grandfather. In the official survey the tree disappears, leaving only an altered line. The difference between a small natural landmark and an authorised diagram reveals how relations among field, home and food have been transformed. With the stamp 'verified' applied, the social life of a falsehood is not extinguished but organised. Through the opposition of objects, the narrator recalls the novel's earlier landscape of pond, field and bridge. Yet the recollection of the babool tree cannot alone settle legal ownership; it indicates a discrepancy requiring investigation.

Surmani or Surmuni: The Unstable Identity of a Written Name

A woman's name is only partly legible on a sheet: it might be 'Surmani' or 'Surmuni'. Alongside this uncertainty are mutually inconsistent remarks such as 'present', 'applicant absent' and 'documents insufficient'. The writer's device removes documentary language from its supposed position as stable truth. Given the uncertain spelling, the figure cannot automatically be identified as the Surmani Kaki of an earlier chapter or the Surmani Devi of a later one. Establishing her identity within the text requires additional examination, not an effortless merger of similarly named characters.

'I Sent It Upstairs': The Invisible Chain of Orders

Chandrapal's former clerk admits that he did not lose the file: he sent it 'upstairs', but it never came back. The unidentified agency contained in that word generates a particular tension. Officials, advocates, village leaders, moneylenders and brokers present themselves as possible figures, but no specific person has yet been established. The obscure reference pushes the reader towards another stage of inquiry. Treating the word

'upstairs' alone as proof against anybody would be an unauthorised leap in interpretation.

A Heap of Seals: The Repeated Production of Injustice

Entries for attendance, absence, verification, rejection, adjournment and missing records pile up. The children recognise that injustice is produced not only in a single violent moment but through the accumulation of small administrative actions. Distort a name, alter a date, withhold a copy and then declare an application incomplete: the sequence gives the plot a clear causal structure. The novel's wrongdoing consequently ceases to be merely an abstract symbol of greed and becomes the daily repetition of power exercised through procedure.

Old Seals: The Retirement of an Object and the Persistence of Responsibility

Three worn seals lie in a drawer: one has broken teeth, another rotting wood, and a third letters half-erased. The clerk says they are no longer in use. Ananya asks whether the responsibility for decisions made with them has therefore also ended. This exchange raises an acute question about historical time: an instrument's working life can end while its effects persist in the lives of families. The divergence between the age of a physical object and the duration of social harm deepens the long narrative's sense of time.

'B. H.' on the List: The Distance Between Indication and Proof

A folded sheet taken from the former clerk's inner pocket contains names, amounts, file numbers and the initials 'B. H.' The characters take these letters as a possible indication pointing towards Batuknath Hariharan. Yet neither a complete name nor an exact match of signatures has been found; the abbreviation does not constitute full proof of an offence. The narrative skill lies in making two letters thicken suspicion while legal caution waits for their meaning to be established. This tension creates a natural need for further investigation.

Red Ink Changing Colour and the Magical Sign

Light from a broken window makes a red seal appear black. A red mark is seen on the stone beside the Channa stump, although whether it is ink or earth remains uncertain. This visual instability generates dramatic meaning. Meera attributes the changed colour to wrongdoing, but the critical reader must distinguish narrative metaphor from physical inference. The window's light, the layer of dust and the frightened perceptions of the characters give meaning to the experience of colour; they do not create new external evidence by themselves.

'B. H.' and the Parallel Spread of Rumour

The abbreviation is found inside the record room; outside, on the veranda, whispers grow about Batuknath, Chandrapal's closed door and rumours that Raghav has fled. The writer's parallel arrangement shows how quickly ambiguous material emerging from an inquiry can become a definite accusation in public speech. The narrator expressly indicates that the amount of truth contained in the rumours is uncertain. Criticism must attach particular weight to this admission: if the vigilance surrounding names itself becomes the crocodile of rumour, the enterprise loses its moral basis.

A Protected Copy and the Appeal Not to Destroy the Dust

Ananya wraps the original sheet in red cloth and asks that the marks left by hands and the dust of time be preserved. The scene reveals concern for the document's physical integrity. Copies are necessary, but conserving the marks on the original paper is also part of the story's inquiry. Material traces here are potential sources of historical knowledge. They are not to be kept only as sentimental relics, but as material available for careful comparison.

Refusing to Take the Key: The Collective Distribution of Responsibility

Bhikhari Lal places his key before Ananya and says that he can open the lock but cannot stand guard alone. Ananya does not pick up the key. She tells him it should remain in his hand, though that hand will no longer be alone. This is a subtle decision in the development of character. Rather than taking all the powers of a government employee into the hands of the community campaign, the group seeks to involve him in a network of responsibility. A limit remains: the lawful custody of the actual archives and the procedures governing them will continue to require separate consideration.

From the Stain to the Knock at Every Door: Foreshadowing

A list of twenty pages bearing seals is compiled; many names emerge from the dust; and finally the powder of dried ink scatters from its container. The story raises a precise question: whose hand wielded the seal? Chapter 146 does not supply a final answer, but arranges the traces through which it may be sought. The next chapter must turn towards finding the actual homes associated with these names. 'The Stain of the Seal' is therefore not simply a momentary climax; it is a decisive intermediate stage in the investigation of an extensive institutional network.

Critical Section 248 | Original Chapter 147 — The Knock at Every Door

From the Language of Command to the Language of Request

In Chapter 147 the children carry copies of the files from house to house, but at the doors they do not say, "Present yourselves." The note left at a closed door says instead: whenever you wish, we can come and listen. This linguistic transformation contains the novel's principal social experiment. The old court notice commanded people; the letter carried on the new journey of names asks for a person's consent. The fundamental change in the plot is not the abolition of institutions but the attempt to rewrite them in a different grammar of human relationships.

Surmani Devi's Petition and Grief Written by Another

The first house belongs to Surmani Devi. The old woman's sight and hearing have diminished, yet she becomes alert as soon as a name is spoken. She says that she did not write the petition herself: the patwari's son wrote it. Where, she asks, was her weeping in his writing? Aruni records this discrepancy as "the writer was another; the suffering belonged to the first person." The sentence discloses the central problem of narrative representation: the voice that puts words on paper is not the voice of the person who underwent the experience. The criticism applies this distinction also to the novel's own practice of storytelling.

The Brass Box: Joining Seeds to the History of Land

Surmani Devi's granddaughter shows a brass box containing two seeds, a broken bangle and a clod of soil from the field. These objects bring together several temporal layers of the family's life: cultivation, a woman's existence, separation and memory. The smell of an object cannot acquire the same legal standing as an official land-survey register, but within the courtyard it conveys what the land means. This material recurrence establishes a connection with the earlier chapter on seed preservation within the novel's larger structure.

Rameshwar's Old Calendar: A Family Clock Stopped in Time

Rameshwar Sah is no longer alive. In his house a calendar twelve years old remains fixed at the year in which he last went to court. The dates in the record room and on the wall differ; in the family's experience, however, the intervening years have become one long wait. This discrepancy raises the ordinary source-critical question of how time has been reckoned. The

narrator interprets it symbolically as time brought to a standstill; criticism must not present the chronological difference as a fact already reconciled.

Bhikhari Lal's Apology and the Daughter-in-Law's Reply

Rameshwar's daughter-in-law does not immediately forgive Bhikhari Lal when he apologises for possibly having handed over an old slip bearing a date. She says only, "If you have understood, write it down." The ethics of forgiveness here connects with the earlier night-time episode involving Batuknath: an emotional admission cannot replace concrete action. Bhikhari Lal writes in his notebook that a slip bearing a date can become hunger inside a household. The evidence of his transformation is not tears but a new language for experience and the work he undertakes next.

Phulkumari's "Incomplete Proof" and an Empty Stomach

The paper explaining why Phulkumari's scholarship was stopped says "incomplete proof." Her mother replies that it was not the proof but the stomach that was left unfilled; consequently, her daughter abandoned her studies. This brief exchange exposes the separation between the official reason stated in a document and the lived cause recognised by the injured family. Ananya requests permission to write it down. The mother stipulates that her daughter be represented as a bearer of rights, not an object of pity. The social narrative centres not on a donor's generosity but on a lost right to education.

The Closed Door: Silence as an Independent Answer

Some households open their doors; others fasten the bolts from within. The group does not press such families, but leaves a short note and proceeds. This is a concrete extension, within the story, of Meera's earlier practice of defending the right to remain silent. The silence behind a closed door is respected, although the role of those who create fear remains a separate question. Through this distinction the novel refuses to treat an individual's refusal as the failure of a collective campaign. It experiments with keeping help available while safeguarding people's autonomy to decide.

Murari the Photocopier's Additional Copies

Murari, the former photocopy-shop operator, returns several copies that he had withheld because payment was outstanding. Some contain statements more complete than those in the original file, the edges of maps, or the final line spoken by a woman. The irony is sharp: copies withheld for financial advantage now assist the search for truth. Devika makes clear that their usefulness does not erase the wrong of withholding them. The

incident resists a simplified psychology of character: evidence of present value may survive within an earlier act of wrongdoing.

The Unlit Lamp: For Those Who Did Not Consent

At night, near the Channa grove, only names for which permission has been granted are read aloud. For families that withheld permission, an empty lamp is placed without wick or flame. In this visual arrangement absence is given a location without its voice being appropriated. Near the stump and its shoot, figures of magical realism, this small sign makes the novel's conception of privacy tangible. Not lighting a lamp is itself a decision; the scene teaches the dignity of refusal made visible.

Adulterating Falsehood: A New Strategic Turn in the Crime

Chandrapal's associates conclude that stopping the house-to-house campaign will be difficult. They therefore decide to mix fictitious victims, incorrect documents and false accusations with genuine names. The incident matters because it supplies a definite cause for the next conflict. Previously the wrongdoers suppressed papers; now they plan to corrupt the network of evidence itself. Increasing the number of names will not automatically increase the force of truth. Faced with this new danger, the plot passes from emotional remembrance into the complicated procedures of verification.

Meera's Five Rules and the Slowness of Justice

Meera lays down five rules: listen to every account twice, keep copies of documents separately, distinguish the language of accusation from that of experience, do not declare anyone guilty before a crowd, and investigate whenever falsehood is suspected. These rules introduce a new artistic self-restraint into the novel's spoken world. The elderly litigant warns that inquiry must not become so slow that another generation passes away. Their exchange contains a real tension between caution and the pace of action. It should be understood not as a difficulty miraculously resolved, but as the condition of a long struggle.

The Closing Sign: Falsehood Dressed as Truth

At the chapter's end Ananya enters in her first-day list Surmani's soil, Rameshwar's calendar, Phulkumari's hunger, the closed door, Murari's copies and the approaching scheme of adulteration. The reader thus understands that the next turn will concern not the quantity of evidence but its integrity. The faint sound of a crocodile sliding through water becomes a metaphor for the impending conspiracy. This ending is no celebration of justice achieved. It urges vigilance against untruth wearing the costume of truth and creates a natural bridge to Chapter 148.

Inter-Sectional Discussion: From Soil to the Knock at Every Door

The narrative movement of Critical Sections 241–248 marks a decisive transition in the novel. Following the Videha Theatre Festival, the travelling chaupal arrives at the veranda of an institutional court; from there the story passes through the record room, the sack of discarded papers, the threshold of missing names, fear within the office, the stain of the seal and, finally, the consent-seeking knock at every door. This is not merely a catalogue of social ideas but a causally connected series of events. As spectators' testimony from the play encounters judicial documents, the author shows that keeping public memory alive requires entering the darkness of files, struggling with damaged pages and asking permission at the doors of families.

The principal material objects of these eight chapters include a folded notice arriving on a bicycle, the shoe-worn stone of the veranda, an old key, dust from a cupboard, a fragment of a marriage document, the corrupted family name of a student, a knot of red thread, a sack of waste paper, a thumb impression, the wet bottom of a boat, the courtyard of Jasoda's niece, three secured copies, a worn seal, dried ink, a brass box, an old calendar, a closed door and an additional photocopy. Continuity among these objects is not mechanical: each acquires a role different from its first use. A ticket or notice serves the machinery of authority; a slip becomes an archive of human time; what has been discarded can become a witness to suppressed social memory.

The organisation of time is this sequence's sharpest dimension. The old litigant's twenty-three-year case, a twelve-year-old calendar, repeated stamps recording receipt and the failure to produce even one order all disclose the life-denying pace of institutional time. Within the court, dates on files move forward, while inside families a year may stand still or an entire generation may pass. The writer links this inequality to the image of the crocodile's chewing. Even so, a date appearing on a letter and a different date retained in oral memory are not thereby proved identical; their factual reconciliation belongs to further inquiry.

The changing arrangement of speakers is equally clear. During the name-game of Chapter 140, Ananya holds the register; in Chapter 141 the old litigant and the clerk speak; in Chapters 142–143 Bhikhari Lal, the widow, Meera, Devika, the advocate and the remains of the file acquire voices. Jasoda's niece relates the family's time behind a name in Chapter 144. In Chapters 145–146 the fear inhabiting the chambers of the criminal network and the munshi's hesitation develop in parallel. In Chapter 147, Surmani Devi, Rameshwar's daughter-in-law and Phulkumari's mother impose their own conditions on the narration of events. Within ostensibly

omniscient narration, numerous characters thus speak from within the limits of their particular knowledge.

The story repeatedly preserves the distinction between emotional testimony and factual verification. Seeing a warehouse on Jasoda's former field does not prove everyone there guilty; supposing that Panna resembles her own brother does not establish an identity; the munshi's "I passed it upward" does not name whoever gave the order. The initials "B.H." do not determine an entire person, and it remains uncertain whether the red stain is ink or earth. Meera prescribes the separation of accusation from experience. This self-critical discipline keeps the long novel's magical imagery on the plane of possibility. It would be unfair to the reader for criticism to convert an intentionally uncertain sign into a final conclusion.

Magical-realist occurrences must also be read on a distinct plane. Stone seems to hold breath within itself; dust in the record room forms letters; names appear to leave the paper and walk towards their homes; the Channa tree's shadow reaches the court; the stain of a seal changes colour. Such moments intensify social experience through images and sounds. Yet the novel's sequence of events also contains people boarding boats to find families, officials recounting records, and children making copies. The miraculous metaphor does not replace this human labour.

Two particular textual questions remain open. In the chapter on the sack of waste paper, a second, night-like ending follows an apparent conclusion: the record room is closed and the old litigant's petition is read again. The chronology is not clearly distinguished; both an intentional circular pattern and editorial repetition must therefore remain possible explanations. Likewise, the reference to Batuknath's own absence from the mansion and Bhikhari Lal's shifting description as peon and temporary clerk require careful comparison with earlier chapters. Declaring such fine discrepancies automatically to be magical realism, without examination, would not constitute criticism.

This sequence ends not with a judicial victory but with the emergence of a difficult new crisis. The accounts read with consent, the unlit lamp for a closed door, Murari's preserved additional copies and Bhikhari Lal's written remorse protect the community's names. Yet Chandrapal's group decides to mix false victims and incorrect papers among true names. The next question is no longer simply whether suppressed truth can emerge, but how accusation, experience, sources and inducements are to be distinguished among the many voices now heard. It is in this unresolved situation that the narrative acquires a credible long duration.

Critical Section 249 | Original Chapter 148 — Detecting the Adulteration

From Knocking on Doors to Testing Documents

At the end of the preceding chapter a conspiracy was devised to mix false accusations and fabricated statements into the list of genuine cases. Chapter 148 turns that warning into an actual scene. The children gathered near the Channa stump are now more than recorders of names: they examine the sources of statements and the physical fabric of documents. The campaign's methods change in response to the opposing side's manoeuvre. This is not merely a didactic chapter; it shows communal practice altered by a crisis that has occurred. The narrator does not separate sensitivity from testing, but keeps the limitations of every investigative device in view.

The Assumed Name Bhola Mandal and Bhikhan Sah's Confession

The first visitor of the morning calls himself Bhola Mandal. His old gamchha, bundle and trembling voice are the external props of a victim's role. His account begins to falter under questions about the smell of the soil, domestic memories of the day of the first hearing and the folds of the file. At last he identifies himself as Bhikhan Sah and admits that Raghav's men promised him two hundred rupees. His statement shows the social production of a lie: the counterfeit witness is himself poor, but that poverty does not annul the consequences of his manufactured accusation.

The Broken Rhythm of Grief and the Over-Simplicity of a Statement

The answers given by the man calling himself Bhola are smooth, rehearsed and general, while Jagmaya's sentences contain long pauses. The writer dramatises the differences between their situations through this contrast of rhythms. In criticism, however, it cannot become a universal criterion: a truthful person may speak clearly and steadily, while a liar may tremble quite naturally. Within the narrative, vocal rhythm is considered alongside a document's folds, record numbers, household particulars and separate questioning. The tension arises from that combined construction. Emotional demeanour alone is no permanent ground for a verdict of guilt.

The Body of Paper: New Folds and Artificial Age

Devika examines the folds in the paper, its layer of dust and the sheen of the ink. A false sheet has been made to look old, but its fresh creases and bright blue colour appear inconsistent. In this scene the novel renders a record not as an abstract fact but as an object that can be touched. Reading a file almost as a body allows the characters to share their experience of

inspection. Yet visible features alone cannot conclusively date the paper: the passage offers grounds for caution, not laboratory confirmation.

Jagmaya's Receipt and the Two Names "Harimohan/Mohan"

The second visitor is Jagmaya. She brings a receipt issued in the name of Harimohan Jha, although within the family her husband was called "Mohan." This small relational detail exposes a difference between the language of legal records and that of home. Her recollection of two puris, pickle and a medicine box brings a journey to court into the everyday life of a household. The receipt's oil stain and the matching record number give the inquiry a direction; the clerk sees a possible connection with the missing edge of the main file. The receipt's full evidentiary status is not decided immediately: arrangements begin to make a secure copy.

Jagmaya's Ownership of the Original

At the end of the night Jagmaya wishes to leave her receipt with those keeping watch. Meera would rather leave the original in Jagmaya's hands and take a copy. This seemingly small decision prevents the guardians of memory from becoming owners of a new archive. The original object and its symbolic dignity remain with the family, while a copy can serve the communal inquiry. Here the narrator shows that trust does not mean confiscating evidence; it means constructing a relationship under the limits of consent.

Three Young Men, One Handwriting: Signs of Collective Fabrication

In the afternoon three young men bring different stories, but their handwriting is identical and several sentences recur. They are seated separately and questioned about the direction of their homes, the sound of their fathers' voices and where their papers had been kept. The questioning suggests that the possible source of falsehood lies in a collectively rehearsed exercise. A child says he saw one young man on Raghav's veranda the previous night; Meera promptly removes the child from the crowd for his safety. Identifying a source and protecting that source belong to the same event.

Accepted, Incomplete and Suspect: Three Levels of the Archive

By evening the papers have been divided into three piles: accepted statements, incomplete statements and statements suspected of adulteration. This classification supplies the narrative with a new organising device. Earlier, hearing a name and entering it in a register had been paramount. Now both suppressing truth and accepting an account too hastily have become dangers within the story. The designation "suspected of adulteration" matters, since these papers are not thrown away

after being pronounced definitively false. Every sheet is preserved for subsequent examination of its connections.

Murari's Scratch: The Grey Boundary Between Wrongdoing and Resistance

Murari the photocopier admits that under pressure he made three false copies, but left a tiny scratch on each. The character holds together an admission of wrongdoing and a suppressed wish to be found out. The narrator does not turn him into an innocent hero: Meera records the offence separately from the identifying mark. This complexity breaks down a simple division of characters into black and white. A person made an instrument of deception may nevertheless leave upon that instrument an unwanted point of identification. The result is an ethical unease within the fiction.

The Box of Suspected Adulteration: An Opening into the Search for the Network

At night the suspect documents are placed in a separate box. The physical container becomes an intermediary narrative object: what may be false is not discarded, but neither is it mixed with accepted truth. Sources, suspicions, testimony and the opponent's plan are gathered in one place. The box creates the conditions in which the next chapter can open as a "map of the network." Its significance is not a political slogan, but the unfinished labour of examination.

The Old Ghost's Shadow and the Deferral of Judgment

Observers offer different interpretations of the white smoke or black shadow arising near the stump. Aruni notes the presence of an "invisible sign" but withholds judgment. This magical-realist moment maintains the novel's marvellous dimension without supplying the last word on evidence. The supernatural suggestion acts as a metaphor for fear and memory; the three piles of paper indicate the next stage of actual inquiry. That distance between symbol and institutional procedure is decisive for criticism.

Critical Section 250 | Original Chapter 149 — Mapping the Network

From Individual Deception to a Multicentred Conspiracy

Chapter 148 presented attempted adulteration at the level of individuals and papers; Chapter 149 reads the same operation through the connections among several places. A box tied with red thread, folds in forged papers, Murari's scratches and smoke from a veranda together begin to form the lines of a network. The plot's central question shifts from "Who told the lie?" to "Where did the paper travel from?" The change reveals not merely a hierarchy of social wrongdoing, but an interdependent arrangement of movements and exchanges.

Two Production Sites: Paper Folds and Corner Marks

Comparing Bhikhan's sheet with the three young men's copies reveals different marks of manufacture. Some sheets share the same folds and trimmed corners; others carry different scratches. The children realise that the falsehoods were not all fabricated in a single place. Through these fine material distinctions the novel prevents "network" from remaining a merely grand metaphor. Local sites where the papers were worked on appear along its edges. Yet the exact rooms in which they were produced still have to be investigated.

Incense and the Smell of the Office: A Sensory Map

Devika detects the smell of incense on several pages. The clerk says that such smoke rises from Raghav's veranda in the evenings. Smell thus becomes a sign of possible movement: a connection invisible to the eye is awakened through olfactory memory. Yet the same smell cannot uniquely identify one veranda. The narrator sets it alongside other correspondences. Criticism must observe this coexistence rather than treating a magical-seeming sensory capacity as unalterable physical certainty.

Jagmaya's Bag: Family Evidence for a Counter-Narrative

Jagmaya brings Harimohan's medical prescription, half a money-order slip and a yellowed photograph. Set against the rehearsed papers supporting false accounts, these objects disclose the old continuities of a family's life. The photograph of a gathering on the veranda, the matching gamchha and the oil stain on a receipt give greater density to the narrative claim. In this scene a woman becomes not merely the person identified as a victim but a fellow investigator. Her private bag adds an important edge to the public map of the network.

Three Circles: Raghav, Murari and the Record Room

Under the stump's shade three circles are drawn with charcoal: Raghav's veranda, Murari's shop and the court record room. Along the connecting lines are written "smoke," "scratch," "key," "false seal" and "hired testimony." The image exemplifies the novel's visual technique: the reader sees dispersed events on a single map drawn in earth. But the circles are not findings of criminal guilt; they are preliminary indications of connections. As information about other places is added, the map changes shape.

Kailash Prasad: From "the Clerk" to a Witness with a Name

The clerk identifies himself as Kailash Prasad and admits having temporarily removed some files. By giving his name, a generic character identified by occupation enters a story of individual responsibility. His role does not amount to an automatic or complete confession of guilt. He speaks within the limits of his fear for his job and the actions he acknowledges. Writing his name combines an element of surrender with the beginning of trust. The village children gain another helper, but the reckoning with his former silence remains unfinished.

Files Concealed Beneath a Wooden Plank

Prompted by Kailash's memory, a loose plank in the record room is lifted. Beneath it lie three thin files, two pages from a receipt ledger and an incomplete index. The old ashram seal and a court reference number appear on the same sheet. This discovery is a more concrete narrative achievement than a general hint of conspiracy: a physical place, objects and connected marks have been found. Nevertheless the mere appearance of a seal does not establish who ordered its use. The map sharpens the central suspicion without resolving it.

Bhikhari Lal's Key: The Question of Passive Mediation

Bhikhari Lal says that if the paper went out, the key must also be accountable. He reconsiders his earlier limited role as the employee who turned it. The exchange between Kailash and Bhikhari Lal turns on "I did not see it" versus "Your key turned there." The narrative abandons a simple line between hero and villain to depict the ethical complexity of minor administrative offices. Responsibility cannot reach the actual issuer of an order unless its range is traced, but it would also be unjust to place the entire blame on those holding the lowest posts.

Bhikhan's Broken Statement and Murari's Minute Scratches

Bhikhan, who earlier arrived posing as Bhola, now offers his actual admission in a trembling voice; Murari explains the method by which he made his identifying marks. These two reappearances revise earlier events

by supplying new information. The statements of men formerly recognised as instruments of deception now help trace the network's routes. In this renewal, a character's position within a long narrative does not remain fixed. Even so, documentary comparison must continue alongside the emotional significance attached to trembling speech and scratched paper.

The Map Expands and the Stump's Shadow Shrinks

By evening the map drawn in the earth has spread so far that the stump's shadow appears small beside it. This material image represents a change in narrative scale: the memory rooted in a local grove now extends to institutional and economic locations. Satyavrat repeatedly alters his title before settling on "First Copy," thereby leaving the authority to investigate in communal hands. The adjective "first" is crucial: the writer explicitly presents the map as open to revision.

The Next Entry: From the Seal's Rubber to Its Handle

Raghav grows anxious that the procession's reading of names will soon reach his door in documentary form. Beyond locating where the papers were manufactured, it is now necessary to investigate the seal's material history. This prepares the next chapter, "The Shadow of the Seal." Mapping the network is not an ending sufficient in itself, but an artistic means of producing another question: what route was taken by the wood, rubber and hands of the seal with which authority was stamped? That unfinished line sustains the immediate momentum of events.

Critical Section 251 | Original Chapter 150 — The Shadow of the Seal

Missing Rubber and the Surviving Handle: A Drama of Objects

After the network has been drawn between the ashram, veranda, court and office, the narrative fixes its attention on a small object: a seal. Rubber may be erased while the wooden handle survives. This proposition brings together the endurance of materials and the long-lasting consequences of authority. The seal itself does not speak in the chapter; memory of its former use, a waste-dealer's account and papers held by families confer meaning upon it. Through a tangible remnant, the novel makes its extensive network something that can be touched.

From the Map to the Ashram's Waste-Paper Shop

Searching for the whereabouts of the ashram's donation ledger, Meera, Ananya, Bhikhari Lal and Murari go to Chhedi's waste-paper shop. The journey covers little distance but has decisive social meaning. Labour conventionally regarded as lowly because it destroys or disposes of paper now becomes a potential guardian of memory. Chhedi's account opens the story of the movements of red thread, sacks of documents and a heavy piece of metal. A person positioned outside the institutional centre thus witnesses part of its history.

The Season of Nag Panchami: An Alternative Memory of Dates

Chhedi, the collector of waste paper, remembers not a precise date but the season around Nag Panchami. A possible correspondence is noticed between that period and the report of an old court seal going missing. The event sets popular memory and the official calendar before us as two distinct systems of reckoning time. The narrator does not declare an exact match, only that the search has "come closer." Caution is necessary with this partially certain sense of time: a remembered festival season can indicate a direction but cannot serve as final proof of a date.

"Sikka," the Itinerant Buyer of Metal

Chhedi says that he sold the heavy metal piece to an itinerant purchaser who travelled towards the Darbhanga market and was known as "Sikka." The reference shifts the seal's possible material journey beyond documents into the economic circuits of scrap. The buyer's actual name is not immediately known; the inquiry must therefore proceed through the uncertainty of a popular nickname. The narrative advantage is that the history of one object is distributed across numerous small occupations and temporary places.

"Bha … La …": The Possibility of Bhanu Lal

Seeing incomplete letters on the recovered remnant, Bhikhari Lal remembers Bhanu Lal, an old maker of seals. Similarities of sound among several names could lead to confusion. Through nicknames and incomplete letters the narrative keeps the reader from a definitive answer. Bhikhari Lal attempts to distinguish this mark from his own name. The fragmentary letters function as more than the machinery of a mystery: they are an artistic expression of the uncertainty of identity.

The Curious Term "Compromise Service" in the Donation Ledger

"Compromise service" appears beside an entry relating to Surmani Devi's family. Kailash Prasad indicates that the expression is not customary language in the courts. The idiom of charitable donations and an event connected with litigation appear on the same page. The mixture blurs institutional boundaries: what is labelled service may need to be examined as a possible procedure for extinguishing a claim. Yet the term "service" does not, on its own, conclusively establish a crime. Comparison with other ledgers is required.

Surmani Devi's Empty Lota: Thirst Joined to the Seal

Hearing the news, Surmani Devi abandons her journey to fetch water and comes in search of her family's name. The empty water vessel in her hand connects earlier chapters on thirst with the new investigation of documents. Placing an empty container alongside a half-legible seal allows the narrator to show how papers concerning land and rights eventually reach a thirsty body. What earlier appeared as the social policing of hunger and thirst now becomes the identification of a living person within a chain of records.

The Transition from Documents to the People Behind Them

Once the seal's handle and marks in the ledger have been found, comparison of objects alone is insufficient. Questions arise: whose palm held the handle, which office received the seal, and which ashram kept the accounts? The narrator prepares a transition from the story of things to the entry of human actors. The following chapter's title, "The Hand that Wielded the Seal," announces this shift: the material memory of the object demands the name of the person who bore it.

Chhedi and Murari: Reversing the Meaning of "Waste"

One dealer in discarded paper narrates the movement of old documents; another, Murari the copier, supplies signs of falsification through his scratches. Neither belongs to the regular judicial establishment, yet both small occupations are indispensable to the biography of judicial

documents. The novel makes the work performed on society's margins a narrative source. Both men, however, have had financial interests in the past; the fact that they speak does not automatically make their accounts innocent or unassailable.

The Seal's Circle and the Image of a Closed Decision

The circular imprint of a seal has the power to inscribe "verified" or "rejected" within a petition. Its roundness becomes not only the shape of an impression but an image of social demarcation. In the lines of kabaddi it was possible to cross over when a name was called; outside the seal's circle a name may be deprived of recognition by administrative language. This figurative comparison returns the novel's early image of play to the new phase of inquiry. The meaning of each actual stamped impression must nevertheless be examined in the context of its particular paper.

The Meaning of the Shadow: Not a Verdict but Preparation for the Hand

Chapter 150 throws light on the seal's history, yet questions remain: who signed the documents, what verbal instructions were given, and who benefited? Its title "Shadow" is therefore apt. The effects of the object are visible while the full chain of causes stays obscured. Material remnants of documents become a prelude to the human admissions that follow. The narrative preserves the tension of investigation without supplying a complete answer.

Critical Section 252 | Original Chapter 151 — The Hand that Wielded the Seal

From Bhanu Lal's Handle to Ramesh's Family Memory

After the handle is found, Ramesh the seal-maker brings forward his father Bhanu Lal's name and his recollections. His father had taught him how to apply a seal, but also bequeathed a fear of asking questions about it. In this paternal inheritance an occupation is not simply a craft; it becomes a self-protective silence. Relief and fear inhabit Ramesh at once. His father's name is now linked with public questioning, while the duty of a new generation has also opened up. The story does not treat responsibility as a simple inheritance of guilt; rather, it creates an opportunity to ask questions.

Wood Grain and Grains of Ink: Impressions of Invisible Labour

Ananya examines the handle's circular shape, Aruni the grains of black ink beneath it, and Devika the grain of the wood worn by sweaty palms. The close observations of the three characters provide different sensory perspectives. The body of the object holds the possibility of many former hands, but comparison is needed before determining whose hand touched it and where. Such description transforms an abstract image of criminality into the study of an object's history of use. The idea that wood retains memory after the rubber of a seal has disappeared lies at the centre of the novel's narration through objects.

Bhikhari Lal's Old Phrase: "I Merely Delivered It"

Bhikhari Lal admits that he used to deliver stamped papers without reading them. For him this seemed a minor duty of employment, but what he carried might have been a notice uprooting someone's household. He begins to question his former complacency. The minor employee within the hierarchy of an office emerges as an assistant to a corrupted system. Nevertheless his remorse does not automatically identify those above him who issued orders: the inquiry into personal participation and the search through the structural network must proceed together.

Haricharan's Absence and the Ashram's Ready-Made Answers

Haricharan's stern message has already arrived, but he does not appear in person at first. Two young men from the ashram bring copies of its donation ledger and recite prepared phrases: public welfare, convenience, service. The difference between representatives and an absent leader is important. The young men cannot answer questions outside their educated stock of expressions; asked "Convenience for whom?" their language

falters. The novel reveals a rehearsed, mask-like voice designed to protect the image of a political-religious institution, not proof of every individual's guilt.

Mohan's Letter and Surmani's Lota

Jagmaya brings Mohan's incomplete letter, expressing how a man had become a stranger on his own land after the seal was applied. Surmani Devi places her empty water vessel beside it. In this arrangement of objects, the written deprivation of rights and the absence of water join along one figurative line. The combination connects the earlier discussion of thirst to the inquiry into the institutional network. The letter's incompleteness does not deprive it of value, though the timing and original form of each assertion still require verification.

"A," "Ch," "R," "A": The Difference Between a Code and an Inference

Four letters appear in Bhanu Lal's register. Bhikhari Lal suggests possible expansions: Adalat (court), Chandrapal, Raghav and Ashram. The children are astonished, but Meera refuses to treat them as proof of criminal responsibility. This is a test of the inquiry's self-restraint. The proposed expansions may help direct the search, but alternative meanings remain possible. By sharpening this difference, the narrative makes the reader await the comparison of dates that follows.

Matching Three Dates: An Inquiry Gathers Density

Separate groups compare the dates of court proceedings, petitions in Chandrapal's office and meetings on Raghav's veranda. Some days coincide, making the proposed interpretation of the four letters appear more plausible. Coinciding dates, however, cannot fully identify the source of an order. The narrator advances the investigation through this very insufficiency. As fragments of evidence accumulate, the plot relies less on conjecture and moves towards increasingly concrete acts of comparison, searching and copying.

Ramlakhan Sahay: The Choice to Listen Rather Than Pursue

A man carrying an umbrella and bearing an old cut near his ear comes to be identified as Ramlakhan Sahay. In searching for him, the children do not stage a violent chase; Meera has already taught them caution. Ramlakhan says that he merely carried papers. Bhikhari Lal immediately compares this defensive sentence with his own former claim. The similarity creates two mirrored intermediaries within the story: one an employee of a public office, the other a carrier for a private network.

Sealing Blank Paper First: A Claim of Reversed Procedure

Ramlakhan admits that on some occasions a blank sheet was stamped before words were entered upon it. Questions also arise about new copies made under older dates and court duplicates stored with the donation ledger. His account brings the network of wrongdoing more clearly into view, but the statement remains partial. The writer shows the direction of the conspiracy without filling in every role. Ramlakhan's assertion that "everyone did it" may itself be a defensive idiom of collective blame.

Ramlakhan's Glance Before Haricharan

Haricharan arrives alleging that the ashram has been insulted. Seeing the way Ramlakhan looks towards him, Meera records the glance as a "sign of mutual acquaintance." It creates dramatic tension, but is neither a verbal admission nor a verified order. With this one sentence the novel reminds both narrator and investigator of their limits. The cause of the moisture that appears without rain in the original chapter's empty water vessel is likewise entered as uncertain: an image arises, not a verdict.

From the Wooden Handle to the Source of the Order

At the end Meera distinguishes the hand from the order. Bhanu Lal's seal, Ramesh's memory, Ramlakhan's partial statement, Haricharan's defensive language and the page bearing the code all point towards a network. Yet the person or role giving instructions behind the body that applied the seal remains undisclosed. Ananya resolves to write down the orders the following day. The ending preserves the causal sequence of investigation: every piece of knowledge the reader acquires produces further questions.

Critical Section 253 | Original Chapter 152 — The Source of the Order

The Invisible Character Called “Above”

At the centre of Chapter 152 is not the entrance of a single criminal but the habitual language of evasion embodied in the word “above.” Ramlakhan's earlier reply—he had merely delivered papers—and his references to instructions from higher up left the source of the order unnamed. Meera directs attention not towards an assault upon an individual but towards the movement of sentences from one place to another. The narrative thereby renders hierarchy as a linguistic network. “Above” ceases to designate any one identifiable person; it becomes a common name, usable at many points, for pushing responsibility elsewhere.

Unsigned Slips: Decisions First, Documents Afterwards

In Bhikhari Lal's old box are slips with red borders: hold back the file, delay supplying a copy, write that the original could not be found. No signature is clearly legible. Ramlakhan maintains that these were not direct orders, only reminders of decisions already made. Institutional language thus reverses the apparent sequence of events: a meeting first settles the matter, and the official file subsequently gives the decision its documentary shape. The discovery is significant for the plot, but identifying who wrote the slips and establishing the relation between each instruction and its consequences still require separate verification.

Mahavir Pathak Enters: The History of an Intermediary Scribe

Ramlakhan names Mahavir Pathak. Within the novel, people identify him as a scholar of scripture from Batuknath's time, an adviser on the ashram's accounts, and a possible drafter of Chandrapal's land documents. He brings into the older network of donations, justice, and money a figure whose work may have made its documentary language possible. His arrival is not the contrived entrance of a grand villain. Rather, he appears as a weary intermediary situated between inherited expressions and offices of authority. That position complicates the search for authorship: a person who helped put words on paper need not have been the sole source of a decision.

Questions in Mahavir's Home and the Limits of Private Material

When Meera reaches Mahavir's home, she proposes distinguishing private papers from entries connected with public affairs. Mahavir initially resists but eventually permits restricted inspection of the ledgers, subject to written consent. The narrator does not allow the enthusiasm of

investigation to become a licence for forcibly taking away rights. In this small discipline the novel's practice of keeping watch over names is applied to the investigators themselves. The more difficult the relationship between an inquiry and its source, the more necessary the boundary of privacy becomes. Respect for that boundary also sustains the possibility of further cooperation.

A Fragment of the Grove and the "Language of Public Welfare"

One entry in the ledger notes the difficulty of claiming a particular portion of the grove directly; it also contains language about reviving memories of religious use and delaying copies of older names. The record exposes how the language of the dispute over Channa Grove's land may have been composed. "Public welfare" is no longer an inherently benevolent intention inside the narrative: the question becomes whose interest the phrase served and what effects its use produced. The ledger page is a significant textual indication pointing towards possible wrongdoing, but the author does not elevate it into a final judicial finding.

The Service-and-Consultation Ledger: One Language, Different Uses

The ashram ledger contains expressions such as settling disputes, reconciling families, encouraging donations, and offering guidance from holy men. Figures written in blue ink along its margins resemble numbers in Bhanu Lal's register. The parallel opens up the possibility of a connection between religious assurances and practical arrangements concerning documents. The narrator does not remain confined to the dictionary meaning of "service." Instead, the inquiry asks whose voice may have been suppressed behind the declaration that service was being performed. Here language is tested through its social uses rather than accepted at its declared face value.

Collective Recollection of the Night the Ledger Was Read

Ramlakhan says that an entry was subsequently read aloud in Chandrapal's office and that Raghav was also present. His recollection creates a bridge between the ledger's language and a meeting outside it. Mahavir's uneasy glance lends the contest between witnesses dramatic force. Yet a remembered presence on a particular night is not the same order of fact as a signed instruction. The chapter gains credibility because the relationship among recollections, ledger pages, and dates is examined gradually. The narrative neither discards oral testimony nor permits testimony alone to establish what the paperwork does not establish.

"Voluntary": The Word at the Centre

A sheet kept inside Mahavir's mattress bears arrows connecting the court, office, veranda, and ashram; at its centre stands the word "voluntary." This assemblage forms the chapter's dramatic focus. Outwardly the term denotes consent, yet under conditions of coercion the same word can become an instrument for concealing fear. The narrative links it to earlier chapters about bodily rights and consent. The gulf between consent written on a page and the will of a living person becomes a reason for the subsequent investigation. The mapped connections remain a clue to that gulf, not proof that every supposed consent was invalid.

Mahavir's Defence: Public Welfare at the Beginning, a Network Beyond Control

Mahavir says that the initial aim was to settle cases involving poor people; later many hands became involved, and he could no longer stop the network. Surmani Devi questions the defence: if he could not stop it, why did his name remain attached to it? The plot demands an account of consequences rather than an account consisting only of professed good intentions. Mahavir's exhaustion invites sympathy, but it is not presented as evidence of his innocence. Admission and self-protection operate together within the character, allowing the narrative to preserve moral complexity without abandoning the question of responsibility.

The Original Stays at Home, a Copy Goes for Public Reading

The original pages of Mahavir's ledger remain under restricted protection in his house, while copies are made for public examination. Through this procedure Meera again establishes that a campaign investigating unjust control cannot itself seize original materials through coercion. For the reader, this is more than an ethical ideal: it is a practical condition for acquiring further sources within the story. If owners of potentially relevant material cannot trust the investigators, the circulation of new evidence may stop. The narrative therefore treats the custody and accessibility of records as separate, negotiable obligations.

The Language of Orders as a Kind of Narrator

"Hold back the file," "public welfare," "service," "consent from above," and "voluntary" do not themselves perform the separate acts described by the story; they shape the circumstances in which characters make decisions. The novel portrays these anonymous directives as something like a concealed narrator: they seek to determine whose version of a life will be written into the record. In rereading those expressions, the community attempts to write the history of how they were produced. This struggle over

linguistic authority adds another dimension to the novel's expansive archival narrative, without equating the words themselves with a completed chain of criminal proof.

Critical Section 254 | Original Chapter 153 — The Names Behind the Signs

Empty Stakes: Giving Absence a Visible Form

For every place where Mahavir's ledger offers a sign rather than a name, Ananya drives an empty stake into the ground beside the stump. Descriptions such as “the farmer from the south” or “the widow across the river” are attached to slips. This is the chapter's central formal device: instead of filling an absence with a fabricated name, the community makes the empty space publicly visible. The watchers acknowledge what they do not know. Those unoccupied stakes do not encourage the invention of another tale; they direct attention towards the search for the missing people.

The Surviving Serial Numbers of the Copy Register

The outer sheet of a file can be replaced, yet older numbers may survive inside the register recording copies. Bhikhari Lal uses such a slight archival remnant to indicate a direction for the search. The narrator introduces the image of “the bones of serial numbers,” transforming an apparently inert administrative figure into the remnant of a missing human body. But a serial number is not a person's entire biography. It merely opens a possible path back towards an older name. The figure of bones gives emotional weight to the clue without converting the clue into proof of identity.

Ramparikshit Paswan and the Memory of Devan

The elderly Ramparikshit Paswan recalls the name of his uncle, Devan Paswan. The children place what has been heard in a first compartment, leaving another compartment marked “Awaiting Evidence.” This arrangement gives equal room to the intimate force of spoken testimony and the need for corroboration from records. The person is held in the space of inquiry, but the original blank has not been prematurely erased. The narrator thus joins the depth of bereavement to the patience of verification. An acknowledged memory is neither dismissed nor allowed to conclude an investigation on its own.

Phoolmati, Phulkumari, Phoolkali: The Uncertainty of Names

In the lettering of an old copy, it is unclear whether a name is Phoolmati or Phulkumari; elsewhere a reference to Phoolkali Devi emerges. The author reveals the danger of confusion among women's names that sound alike. A misread letter might replace one actual life with another. Meera therefore insists on tracing families and consulting an older midwife, boatmen, and village memories. The chapter is not a simple celebration of

a “name recovered”; it depicts the work required to establish the relationship between a name and the person who lived with it.

Kamala's Bundle and the Question of Her Grandmother's Free Will

The reference to a widow across the river prompts Kamala to bring her grandmother's bundle and clod of earth. Surmani Devi asks how a thumbprint taken from a hungry, frightened, or solitary widow can simply be described as an act of “her own will.” The question returns the ledger's language of voluntary consent to the bodily circumstances in which it was supposedly given. The gulf between smooth documentary phrasing and unequal human power becomes a central narrative tension. Nevertheless, the investigation must still determine whose mark or signature appears on each particular page.

The Letter “B”: A Foreshadowing of Batuknath's Name

Within a red stain in Bhanu Lal's coded register, the letter “B” can be discerned. Devika suggests Batuknath, but the single letter does not itself establish that full name. Mahavir Pathak objects to loading an accusation onto “Baba” on the strength of speculation. His resistance intensifies the concealed conflict of authority. The author offers the reader the attraction of a clue while postponing confirmation of the suspect's identity until later scrutiny of spoken statements. The letter functions here as a technique of mystery, not as an official verdict.

“We Shall Read Baba's Words Later”: The Mystery of a Deferred Order

Along one margin of a copy appears the instruction, “We shall read Baba's words later.” The phrase suggests to the characters another layer of spoken directives existing outside orders written on paper. “Baba” may bear religious, familial, and institutional meanings. The narrative preserves this multiplicity while preparing the next chapter's central question. No definite quoted order has yet been tied to a confirmed author; the critical discussion therefore reads the line as a doorway towards a source rather than as the source itself. The postponement is integral to the plot's evidentiary caution.

Mohan's Letter and a Chain of Suppressed Decisions

Drawing on Mohan's letter, Jagmaya points to a line about people whose names disappeared after they spoke about the grove. A thematic relationship emerges between the ledger's margins and the letter: neither records the names of those who gave spoken instructions. This cross-reference strengthens a possibility, but the author and date of each page remain to be determined independently. By placing a witness's experience

beside a gap in institutional writing, the author shows how an archival absence can become a question for collective investigation without becoming a conclusive answer.

The Earth of Two Generations and the Site of the Empty Stump

Ramparikshit brings the remembered name of Devan; Kamala brings earth associated with her grandmother. The walking stick and clod of soil meet beside the stump's roots. In that scene, losses experienced across different social lives and generations converge at a common village site. Channa Grove is not a court of law, but it becomes a centre of relationships among witnesses beyond written records. The enchanted root does not replace the practical search for actual people; it is a living image that gathers the temporal span of that search into a single place.

A Short List and an Immense Task Remaining

By evening, the list provisionally associates Devan with the farmer from the south and Phoolkali with the widow; the old case remains unidentified, the portion of the grove is linked to Baba's words, and the land near the temple enclosure still needs investigation. Phrases such as "Awaiting Evidence," "Provisional Name," and "Investigation Pending" dominate the list. These incomplete formulations give the narrative its scrupulous movement towards truth. After so many chapters, the search has not closed. Instead, it has produced a clearer map of what remains unknown.

Reverential Self-Defence in Place of Suppressed Names

Mahavir says that Baba's words should not be written down. Ananya asks whether Baba was a god or someone who wished to escape accountability. The confrontation places an older sanctity of spoken authority directly before a public question. The plot does not reduce the issue to a simple opposition between belief and disbelief. It asks how responsibility can be identified when unwritten words have had consequences for land and people. The claim of reverence is therefore subjected to the history of its practical effects, rather than dismissed or accepted in advance.

Critical Section 255 | Original Chapter 154 — Baba's Words

From Unwritten Reverence to Words That May Be Questioned

At the end of Chapter 153 comes the assertion that Baba's words ought not to be written down. Chapter 154 explores its implications. "Baba" is a form of address expressing public trust, but the possibility that unwritten decisions operated under the cover of that trust becomes the subject of inquiry. Satyavrat observes that words which have not been recorded require a different method of investigation. The author does not turn reverence itself into an abstract villain; scenes and conversations distinguish the authority of faith from its possible misuse. The critical issue is how an oral statement acquires consequences for others.

Mahavir's Four Ledgers, the Seat Cloth, and the Bell Cord

Mahavir brings surviving objects from the old house: copies of four ledgers, cloth from the ceremonial seat, and the broken cord of a brass bell. Religious sound, the bodily place of authority, and the language of accounts coexist in the collection. None of these objects proves anyone's guilt, but each locates a different kind of memory. Meera treats them neither as objects to worship nor as objects to insult, but as material for examination. The reader thus sees that power is often constituted not merely by formal written orders but by the repeated everyday practices of seating and assembly.

"Consent from Above" and Terms Describing Roles

Expressions such as Baba, above, public welfare, and service occur alongside one another in the ledgers. Meera draws a circle linking them. The circle is not a finding of guilt; it depicts a recurrent pattern of speech: sentences that name no authorised individual can nevertheless make other people act. Haricharan objects that a circle of words does not establish an offence. Ananya replies that a verdict belongs to the court, whereas their task is to trace the circulation of language. This response keeps the narrative's ethical boundary visible while allowing investigation of the social force of impersonal instructions.

Sharda Jha's Memories of the Kitchen

Sharda Jha recalls nighttime meetings behind the household kitchen and utterances made through allusion. She heard such language while undertaking domestic work, not while attending a formal meeting recorded in official minutes. Women's remembered experience opens a concealed entrance into older processes of decision-making. Listening,

serving food, and moving between inner and outer spaces made her a witness with a distinctive perspective. Yet because time separates recollection from event, her account requires comparison with other papers. The story neither dismisses domestic knowledge nor exempts it from the demands of corroboration.

"Baba" Was an Address for Batuknath; Authorship of Orders Is Another Question

Sharda explains that Batuknath Hariharan was addressed as Baba. Meera records this as an identification based on recollection, but separately notes that no direct signature has yet been found. The distinction keeps identification of the person apart from authorship of any particular order. Such caution is essential to the criticism, since the novel's long narrative places Batuknath's earlier public presence and subsequent practices associated with the ashram on different chronological levels. Recognising whom a title designated does not establish who issued an instruction at a specific time.

Bhanu Lal's Slip: The Account of Changing a Date

Ramlakhan produces an old oil-stained slip received from Bhanu Lal, referring to an oral instruction to place the date of a deed of gift in an earlier month. He says that he did not change the date himself. The plot now sketches a possible sequence of wrongful acts within this admission, yet receiving an instruction and actually altering a date are distinct events. Kamala asks what changing the date changes. Aruni explains the implications for the timing of rights. Time is therefore not a neutral number on a form: it may become a means of controlling whose bodily presence and voice count.

The Coexistence of the Light of Charity and the Darkness of Documents

Mahavir recalls Batuknath's contributions to cleaning the pond, schooling, and assistance with marriages. Surmani makes clear that charitable work cannot excuse irregularities in documents. The dialogue prevents the character and institution from becoming one-dimensional. An organisation may genuinely have provided services, while disputed documentary practices may also be connected with it. The narrative asks criticism to preserve this uncomfortable coexistence. Benefits already received should not be denied, but neither should they be used to dispense with scrutiny of the separate claims about ownership and rights.

"Give Them Service and Quiet Them": The Political Use of Compassion

Sharda recalls an old saying: when a name cries out too loudly, give that person service and quiet them. Whether the claims or land documents were returned after rice, medicine, or religious observances were provided is an entirely separate question. Devika and Aruni identify the gap through the language of resistance and pacification. A practice described as sacred public welfare may have become an arrangement for producing silence. By connecting this possibility to the subsequent investigation of the service accounts, the narrator makes the next chapter necessary rather than simply adding another episode.

The Seat Cloth: The Material Place of Authority

The old cloth from the ceremonial seat retains the mixed smells of incense, clarified butter, sweat, and ink. Through their combination, the author places religious practice and the influence of the office in the same space. Meera neither desecrates the seat nor submits to its religious authority; she sets it aside for examination. Her decision shows that the symbolic force of an object cannot substitute for an independently substantiated history. The life of a place, including its routines, smells, and associations, forms a separate strand of the inquiry rather than a verdict in itself.

Remaking the Map of Spoken Statements

The children place a memory-based reference to Baba or Batuknath at the centre of a map. Around it they arrange slips, Sharda's recollections of the kitchen, Mahavir's ledgers, the accounts of Phoolkali and Devan, and Mohan's letter. The person at the centre is no longer simply the name at the top of a chart, but a disputed intermediary among documents and lives affected by decisions. The map helps readers see where particular statements came from; it is not an exhaustive compilation of evidence. Some connecting lines have been established, while others remain incomplete.

The Next Link: The Economic Details of Service

By the end of the day, the meaning of "Baba" is linked to memories of Batuknath, yet the final authorship of the orders remains unresolved. The narrative consequently asks who received what under the name of service and whose voice may have been suppressed in return. The following chapter, "The Service Accounts," develops from this question. Possible evidence of unwritten commands will be sought in lists of expenditure, meals, debts, and the distribution of aid. Narrative sequence and the local

economy become interconnected, making a study of everyday transactions central to the question of responsibility.

Critical Section 256 | Original Chapter 155 — The Service Accounts

“Consequences After the Words”: The Chapter's Guiding Formula

At the opening of the chapter Ananya writes “Consequences After the Words” on a ledger. With this formula, critical attention turns from Batuknath's title, his ceremonial seat, and oral directives towards the everyday lives of families affected by them. The question is no longer solely what Baba said, but what practices followed in particular homes from declarations of service associated with his authority. The shift draws a political and cultural problem close to tangible economic entries and living memories. The narrative seeks consequences without pretending that their causes have already been legally established.

Mahavir's Ledger of Expenditure on Service

The ledger mentions paddy in Phoolkali's name, medical treatment for Devan's family, a communal meal linked to kirtan in the southern hamlet, clothing for a widow, and the suspension of interest owed by Batesar. Such entries supply the chapter with specific incidents rather than merely abstract assertions about charity. When and how each donation actually reached its intended recipient requires further inquiry, but named people and forms of assistance appear within one register. By setting them beside disputed land claims and lawsuits, the narrator makes it possible to investigate whether aid also belonged to a structure of induced silence.

The Gap Between What Was Given and the Rights That Were Taken

Kamala asks why the record mentions paddy in her grandmother's name but says nothing about the land. The ledger's silence supplies no direct answer. Quantities of assistance are specified, while the losses suffered through claims to property are left indistinct. Ananya makes this asymmetry visible to the public. The narrative contrasts the vocabulary of the accounts with the time lived by the affected families: a recorded handful of grain cannot adequately narrate years of dispossession. Nor is the chain of proof yet complete for determining precisely which donation, if any, was made in return for land.

Ramlakhan's Explanation: Aid as a Reason Not to Dispute

Ramlakhan says that the names of people likely to dispute a lawsuit or claim were entered against details of assistance. They could then be told that the ashram had helped them and that further quarrelling would be improper. On this account, service emerges not only as generosity but also as a possible means of social discipline. Yet Ramlakhan himself served as an

intermediary in the earlier network. His statement is therefore useful testimony, not an automatically impartial or conclusive fact. The narrative does not conceal the difficulties involved in giving partial credence to a compromised witness.

Devan's Treatment and His Alleged Attendance in the Same Month

Ramparikshit remembers Devan's earlier assertion that he had not attended court. The ledger dates the medical assistance to the very month in which the disputed attendance was entered. This meeting of timelines makes the suspicion more serious, but coincidence within a month cannot identify the particular person responsible for a false attendance record. The narrator adds another piece of material without announcing a final verdict. This temporal proximity matters especially because the larger chain of events has repeatedly returned to the question of altered dates and the authority created by documentary timing.

Three Voices from the Southern Hamlet: Plural Memory, Not a Single Account

Kailash Mandal, Sakuni Khatun, and Hariballabh Das describe pressure on their families to remain silent in the panchayat after receiving assistance. Three distinct religious and social experiences replace the single supposedly "authorised" account of an event. Sakuni in particular recalls a thumb impression taken from her mother and represented on paper as evidence that she attended a feast. Through this detail, the fingerprint in the file once again becomes a vulnerable boundary of the living body. The gathering expands the scope of testimony, while leaving each account open to its own process of verification.

The Feast List and "Channa Service-Kirtan"

Sharda brings an old list for a meal described as "Channa Service-Kirtan." Families associated with contested land or claims appear particularly often on it. A tension thus develops between the communal religious form of the singing and a possible private purpose of pacifying claimants. The remembered feast becomes an inverted reflection of the earlier chapters on the shared plate and the republic of the kitchen. There, food embodied the hope of equality; here the narrative asks whether it was used to purchase quiet. The juxtaposition exposes a question, not yet a demonstrated uniform motive behind every meal.

The "Silent Feast": A Narrative Reversal of Food

On the last page of Mahavir's ledger appears the entry "Baba's Offering: Silent Feast." Its date is connected with the week of Phoolkali's deed of gift. Sharda recalls that those at the meal were urged to forget the past and

begin anew. Surmani questions the condition attached to forgetting: why should a person who has lost a home be instructed to forget? The scene gives fresh political meaning to the earlier motifs of the oath of salt and shared grain. Food that had promised liberation may also have been deployed to require silence, though the inquiry must still establish the circumstances of the particular transaction.

A List of Reasons for Silence: The Social Body of Fear

Ananya adds a column setting out possible reasons for silence: hunger, medicine, daughters, jobs, reputation, caste, religion, and debt. The list prevents the narrative from reducing silence to cowardice. When witnesses give the appearance of consent to protect their lives, unequal power is already implicated in the conditions of their speech. Understanding those conditions, however, does not automatically excuse wrongful acts in the past. The coexistence of explanation and accountability protects the moral complexity of the characters. A testimony produced under constraint must be read with attention to the constraint itself.

The Half-Raised Hand: An Uncertain Image of Consent

During a public pledge, some hands rise fully, others only halfway, and some do not rise at all. The author turns the gesture of the "half-raised hand" into a crisis of meaning. Amid collective enthusiasm, individual fear has not disappeared; instant unanimity is especially difficult for those whose lives have been shaped by debt and social pressure. The declaration from the platform cannot therefore be taken as proof of completed social transformation. A slight movement of the body offers a more credible sign of justice still unfinished than a confident slogan could provide.

Haricharan's Objection and the Question of Public Good

Haricharan calls the investigation of donations, medicine, and kirtan an insult to the ashram. Satyavrat replies that scrutiny does not destroy work that was good; it may reveal compromised relationships connected with it. The importance of the exchange is not a total rejection of charitable activity, but an investigation of the social conditions attached to its benefits. The novel does not offer the one-dimensional conclusion that all giving is wicked. Instead, it asks whether recipients were pressured to abandon their claims after accepting assistance. Distinguishing the benefit from the condition attached to it is essential.

Ramparikshit's Call for "Inquiry, Not an Oath"

Ramparikshit, Devan's nephew, asks people not to swear an oath of revenge but to continue the investigation. His words turn a potentially climactic emotional scene back towards the unfinished reality of inquiry.

An oath promises immediate moral release; a search demands time, corrections, renewed comparisons, and a willingness to endure uncomfortable answers. The chapter's final effect is therefore a sense of painstaking responsibility rather than an uplifting slogan. Justice remains an activity to be sustained, not a status achieved through a collective declaration.

A Deferred Conclusion: From the Service Accounts to the Debt of Charity

Meera explicitly states that the service ledger may have formed part of an arrangement for producing silence, while certain dates, memories, and incomplete pages still await examination. This principled postponement gives the chapter title its narrative substance. The accounts of service and silence appear suspiciously related, but no complete legal determination has been reached. The transition to "The Debt of Charity" follows naturally: when assistance is transformed into a burden imposed upon those who receive it, by what rule can that debt be assessed, discharged, or challenged? The novel keeps this question open for the next chapter.

Inter-Sectional Discussion: From Adulteration to the Service Accounts

The narrative movement of Critical Sections 249–256 comprises eight concrete turns. The appearance of a fraudulent victim during door-to-door inquiries exposes the danger of adulterated testimony; mapping the network reveals links among centres producing documents; the shadow of the seal leads the search towards the handle and the history of its manufacture; the chapter on the hand that wielded the seal introduces the intermediary's account; the source of the order investigates the language of unwritten instructions; the names behind the signs identify fragments of missing lives; Baba's words place responsibility for religious forms of address under examination; and the service accounts reach the possible exchange of food, medicine, feasts, and silence. In this progression the question changes from "How can a name be preserved?" to "How does a falsehood enter alongside a true name?" and eventually to "Can assistance become a bargain for silence?"

The journeys made by material objects deserve particular attention. They include the freshly folded imitation of an old document, Jagmaya's oil-stained receipt, the reverse-side scratch on Murari's copy, the red-thread box, the three and five circles drawn on the ground, Bhikhari Lal's key, Chhedi's scrap, the surviving handle of the seal, Mohan's unfinished letter, Bhanu Lal's coded register, Mahavir's ledgers, the seat cloth, Devan's old lawsuit, Phoolkali's bundle of earth, Sharda's list for the feast, and the

record of the silent feast. These are objects belonging to different lives. Through such small, visible marks, the author constructs a large, partly invisible network. Each recurrence of an object contributes fresh information, which is why earlier events are reread as the narrative advances.

The distribution of speakers works in two contrary directions. Falsehood, fear, greed, and incomplete admission intermingle in the statements of Bhikhan Sah, the three young men with prepared depositions, Murari, and Ramlakhan. The voices of Jagmaya, Surmani, Ramparikshit, Kamala, Sakuni Khatun, and Sharda bring the experiences of family memory, food, land, and the body into the inquiry. Kailash, Bhikhari Lal, and Mahavir reveal parts of their roles as intermediaries, officials, or writers of records. This polyphony prevents any one omniscient spokesperson from supplying the whole judgment. Ananya maintains the registers; Meera sets procedural limits through consent; Aruni compares objects; Devika interprets their communal meanings; and Satyavrat repeatedly suspends claims that would otherwise become final too quickly.

Judicial time, domestic time, and remembered time move at different speeds throughout this sequence. The dates on old receipts, the season of Nag Panchami, Bhanu Lal's coded register, the oil-stained slip about moving a date, the month shared by Devan's medical aid and alleged attendance, the week of Phoolkali's deed of gift, and the silent-feast entry all create temporal proximities. Yet closeness of dates is not conclusive proof of causal connection. In preserving that distinction, the novel offers its chronology the possibility of credibility: a page from the past opens again on the threshold of the present, but each timeline must be tested alongside its own source.

Many marks remain uncertain within the literary work. The assumed name “Bhola” later gives way to Bhikhan Sah; the relationship of Jagmaya's receipt to the principal file remains possible rather than established; the smell of incense points towards Raghav's veranda; the possible expansion of the code “A/Ch/R/A/B” is not a conclusion in itself; Ramlakhan looks towards Haricharan, but a glance is not a signature; and Sharda links the title Baba to Batuknath while leaving the authorship of any specific directive uncertain. Meera regularly keeps words such as “suspicion,” “recollection,” “provisional name,” and “inquiry” distinct. To erase this uncertainty in criticism would be to destroy a central feature of the narrative.

A layer of magical realism remains present throughout. A shadow rising within the stump, unexpected moisture in an empty water vessel, memory gathered into the fold of a document, the impression of a hand retained by a wooden handle, and light entering a crack make social experience

accessible to the senses. Nevertheless, the characters practise writing "cause uncertain." That restraint does not diminish the beauty of symbolic imagery. On the contrary, it allows the supernatural figure and the labour of actual investigation—matching dates, obtaining copies, securing family consent, and preserving old objects—to maintain distinct forms of presence. The narrative does not use marvels to pronounce unverified public accusations.

The earlier chapters on the shared meal, the common plate, the oath of salt, and the republic of the kitchen acquire an uncomfortable counterimage in this sequence. There, food was an attempt to overcome caste divisions and nourish life. Here, Mahavir's accounts of service expenditure, Channa Service-Kirtan, and the "silent feast" raise the suspicion that food assistance may have been used to weaken people's claims. This inversion is not a mechanical recycling of a symbol; it generates an ethical conflict. The same grain can sustain liberation and, when made into a social debt, demand quiet in return. The novel places this difficult duality at the centre of the investigation.

Instead of a judicial outcome, the section ends with an investigative process that remains open to correction. Bhanu Lal's seal handle, Ramlakhan's partial statement, Mahavir's ledgers, Sharda's memories, and the accounts of affected families together expose the outline of a possible connection between service and silence. But the characters do not automatically designate every donation a crime, condemn anyone by acclamation, or treat an explanation for silence as an acquittal. Ramparikshit's call for "inquiry, not an oath" serves as the sequence's guiding principle. The next chapter, "The Debt of Charity," advances with this uncertainty: if society imposed a debt upon the recipient of assistance, what would constitute its just limit and the means of release?

Critical Section 257 | Original Chapter 156 — The Debt of Charity

Rereading the Half-Raised Hands: From Metaphor to Narrative Cause

At the end of the preceding chapter, "The Service Accounts," the half-raised hands at the public pledge had left a scene unresolved. The present chapter connects that arrested gesture with the private lives of the characters. Meera does not proclaim those who raised their hands fully heroes and those who raised them only halfway cowards. She asks how compassion, gratitude, fear, and pressure arising from vested interests can inhabit the same body. In this way a momentary physical posture becomes the narrative centre of an entire chapter. The earlier question was why someone had left a pledge incomplete; the question now becomes what social price different people must pay to fulfil it.

Kailash Mandal's Memory of Medical Assistance and the Expansion of Debt

Kailash does not deny that the medicines supplied to his father were genuinely useful. He acknowledges that the treatment prolonged his father's life by several months. Later, however, people associated with the ashram converted that assistance into a moral debt invoked to prevent him from raising questions about land. The chapter's art lies in joining these two moments: help during a night of illness and a demand made years afterwards are compressed into a single language of pressure. Through Kailash's trembling hand, the author makes visible the long afterlife of social memory. Once the immediate benefit of the gift is distinguished from the years of silence subsequently extracted in its name, the character's hesitation becomes comprehensible.

Sakuni Khatun's Mother: The Separation of Hunger from Decision-Making

Sakuni's account contains the gift of a sack of grain, but its real turning point is the moment when her mother was made to remain silent in the panchayat on a question of land. "Charity for the poor, decisions in someone else's hands": this arrangement is the inverted reflection of the chapters on the republic of the kitchen and the justice of food. There, grain opened up the possibility of public participation; here, the memory of grain was used to close down a person's right to take part in a decision. The narrator hears Sakuni's subdued voice not as weakness but as the accumulated rhythm of prolonged pressure. Silence, the reader sees, is not

always an inability to speak; it can also be systematic exclusion from the place where decisions are made.

Hariballabh's Manjira: Devotion, Offerings, and Inheritance

Hariballabh's father played the manjira during kirtan, and the family lived on the offerings he received. Because of that history, questioning the ashram had come to seem like an insult both to his father and to devotion itself. Satyavrat asks that a "stain upon devotion" be distinguished from the "use made of offerings." When the sound of an instrument carries familial duty, livelihood, and faith simultaneously, the character's moral predicament cannot be reduced to a simple accusation. Through this subtlety, the narrative breaks the assumed identity between worship and institutional advantage. The manjira is not an object of guilt; what must be examined is the network of silence constructed in its name.

Ramlakhan's Partial Admission: Made into an Instrument, Yet Acting as One

Ramlakhan acknowledges his involvement in wrongdoing while speaking of his family's hunger and his daughter's vulnerability. Bhikhari Lal reminds him that, although he was made into an instrument, he also acted. This short exchange matters to the novel's characterisation because it exposes human pressure at the rigid boundary between victim and perpetrator. Categories resembling "compelled participation in wrongdoing" and "involvement accompanied by admission" are literary means of describing a complicated character, not instructions to grant legal immunity. Ramlakhan's "yes" is not the final instant of self-exoneration. It marks the beginning of the responsibility he must still bear.

Haricharan's Simple Argument and Meera's Answer Through Particulars

Haricharan places the recipient and the giver of charity on an inverted scale: the person who ate is guilty, the person who gave is virtuous. This compressed accusation immediately affects the crowd because one sentence seems to simplify relationships formed over many years. Satyavrat and Meera break that apparent simplicity apart. To accept food when hungry and to exploit another person's hunger in order to suppress a claim are different actions. Meera chooses "particulars" instead of the "scale." Through the opposition between these characters, the narrative sets the allure of a short, forceful pronouncement in a dispute over justice against the slower testimony of lives that must be considered individually.

Kamala's Clod of Earth: Land as the Shelter of the Body

Holding a clod of earth belonging to Phoolkali, Kamala asks why the service accounts mention nothing of her grandmother's land. Mahavir concedes that questions raised by the poor about land used to be treated as greed, whereas the memory of charity was treated as merit. The child's brief question overturns the elderly scholar's entire vocabulary of values. The clod is not merely a remnant of a home: it signifies bodily dignity and the enduring ground of habitation. Through this object the reader senses the disproportion between a temporary plate of donated food and the lasting shelter afforded by a field. In this scene the child is not a passive receiver of knowledge but a critical force driving the narrative forward.

The "Debt-Witness" Register: A New Subdivision of Testimony

Meera has those whose hands were only half-raised entered in a separate register. Four questions govern the rhythm of investigation: what was received, when it was received, what was subsequently prevented, and what language was used to prevent it. Object, time, consequence, and utterance are thus brought together around each name. Beside the earlier service ledger's one-sided perspective of the giver, the new register places the recipient's experience. Repeated phrases such as "have some shame," "remain grateful," and "preserve Baba's honour" cease to appear as isolated rebukes; they form a shared linguistic pattern of suppression. In the shape of a register, the narrative makes an analytical insight available to its readers.

Nirmala the Potter's Inverted Debt: The Unexpected Direction of Labour

Nirmala supplied earthen pots and received grain in exchange. Nevertheless, when the question of documents arose, her family was reminded of the subordinate standing of those who performed service. Here the chapter produces its sharpest reversal: the person who supplied the pots was called a debtor, while the person who received them was presented as a benefactor. Nirmala's clay-covered hands establish an unobtrusive connection with the earlier chapter on the body of labour. The column headed "inverted debt" becomes a new marker in the novel's archival vocabulary. Unless the question of who possesses the authority to keep the accounts is changed, assistance cannot become justice.

Coloured Bundles and a Locked Iron Chest: Foreshadowing Through Objects

The service ledger, the feast list, Bhanu Lal's slip, and the entry concerning the silent feast have been preserved in separate pieces of cloth. Red, yellow,

white, and grey distinguish the documents within the narrative; a white wrapping does not itself prove innocence. Meanwhile, the mention of a locked iron chest plants the seed of the following chapter's mystery. Before providing a solution, the author establishes that a heavy object remains outside the accounts already opened. This construction of a threshold heightens the reader's curiosity, but it does not authorise anyone to fill the chest with imagined contents in advance of its opening.

Assessment: The Story of Giving and the Uses Made of Giving

The chapter does not condemn every act of charity. Kailash's father survived longer, grain relieved hunger, and offerings helped sustain a household: those benefits were real. The problem arises when the memory of assistance is used to shut down questions of rights. The experiences of characters from different religions, occupations, castes, and generations join otherwise separate facets of one idea. In the latter part of the chapter, the iron chest promises to supply the next material focus of this ethical inquiry. The result is not an advertisement for a single metaphor, but a many-layered investigation of conduct, language, and objects beginning with the gesture of a half-raised hand.

Critical Section 258 | Original Chapter 157 — The Iron Chest

Entering the Upper Room: The Archival Geography Within a House

Mahavir Pathak climbs towards the upper room of his house. Dust upon the stairs, cobwebs, old articles used in worship, and a torn mattress create a place where objects associated with family prestige have concealed the material of testimony. The coloured bundles in the preceding chapter belonged to a public setting; the chest in this chapter is shut away in the interior of a private home. This change of location structures the narrative's approach to the inner precincts of authority. Instead of an outwardly dramatic confrontation, the story rests upon the long and careful process of opening a lock, allowing the solution to a mystery to become a bodily experience.

The Key in the Prayer Room: The Veil of Sanctity

The detail that the chest's key is kept in the prayer room gives the story an ironic shape. Material tokens of sanctity and the possible misuse of documents coexist in the same household. The narrator does not, however, automatically designate the prayer room as a scene of crime. The central question is the control exercised over access to the objects. The key does more than open the lock: it raises questions about who was permitted entry into this house's records and what was concealed from whom. Mahavir himself may not know the full significance of the hidden materials; that possibility of ignorance also sustains the narrative tension.

Recording the Lock Before Opening It: Control Over Narrative Pace

When Bhikhari Lal asks for oil to release the jammed lock, Surmani Devi insists that the lock and the marks in the dust should be preserved first. Through this act the author restrains the impatience of the investigators. The chest's outer condition contains information about the incident just as its contents do. The doorway, names of those present, position of the key, and layers of cloth begin to be recorded. The narrative slows down, but this delay generates credibility. Characters who once hurried to obtain an object now protect the circumstances in which that object has been found.

The Manjira, Ritual Vessels, and Family Memory

A broken manjira lying upon the chest recalls Hariballabh's father and the history of kirtan. The instrument that was caught between religious offerings and gratitude in Chapter 156 has become, in this upper room, a mute material presence. Its return is not mere decoration. The reader sees

how one family's devotion became entangled with the public accounts of service. The group of objects acquires emotional density, yet the instrument is not in itself evidence of the alleged wrongdoing. Maintaining that distinction is an essential responsibility of the criticism.

The "Promise" Column in the Food-Distribution Ledger

The first register taken from the chest concerns the distribution of food. Alongside the usual lists of goods, however, it contains a column marked "Promise." Some entries refer to preserving Baba's honour, some to refraining from land disputes, and others to giving consent. This discovery lends more precise language to the suspicions previously raised by the service ledger. A possible relationship between assistance and silence is no longer only an inference drawn from outside the accounts; it appears as a column within the ledger itself. Yet who directed each entry, who agreed to it, and under what conditions remain questions that cannot be settled without further examination.

The Thin "Consent" Notebook: A Contrast Between Size and Consequence

After the thick service ledger, the investigators discover a thin notebook bound in black and labelled "Consent." The dramatic effect arises from this imbalance: the object bearing the weight of outward prestige is thick, while statements capable of altering actual rights are confined to a small notebook. Expressions such as "witness present," thumb impressions, crooked signatures, and the repeated names of witnesses redirect attention away from the grandeur of ritual towards recurring documentary patterns. This thin notebook will become the centre of the following chapter. The object produces a narrative question; it does not yet furnish its solution.

Repeated Witness Names: Suspicion Through Recurrence

Across many pages of the consent notebook, Haricharan, Ramlakhan, Lau's accountant, or Chandrapal's associates repeatedly appear as witnesses. Repetition functions as a narrative signal. Although the events concern different families, different kinds of assistance, and different times, the persistently small group of witnesses points towards the possibility of a concealed arrangement. Repetition alone, however, cannot establish that every particular entry is forged. The characters make it the basis for their coming comparisons. Rather than staging a conclusive revelation, the author prepares a succession of comparative questions.

Thumb-Ink Pads and the Impression of the Body

When lumps of dried ink, two old thumb-ink pads, and a piece of cotton are found, Aruni asks who used to keep the pads. Beneath that question lies

the issue of bodily autonomy: if a thumbprint belongs to a particular body, under what circumstances was its impression placed upon a document? The inventory brings the discussion of trembling or fabricated consent into contact with tangible objects, pressure, touch, and the position of an instrument. Finding the pads does not in itself conclusively prove the fabrication of impressions. It does, however, provide circumstances indispensable to reconstructing how bodily consent may have been obtained.

Phoolkali's Shelter and the Suspension of a Boundary Dispute

The entry relating to Phoolkali Devi states that a boundary dispute was suspended in return for temporary shelter. In one line, protection during a night of disaster and a long-term right to land are bound together in an improper equation. Meera reads the sentence repeatedly: "shelter" names humanitarian relief, while "suspension of the boundary dispute" demands a price for it. The story opens the disturbing possibility that a family searching for a roof on a rainy night was made to undertake a lasting commitment. A conclusion will require comparison with the family's living recollections and the circumstances of the event. This prepares the ground for the next chapter.

Not Batuknath's Signature, but a Mark of Authority

In a corner of one map appears not an ordinary signature but a mark of three lines resembling a trident. The same sign recurs on many pages of the service accounts. Bhanu Lal says that Baba rarely wrote a direct signature. The detail reveals a practice in which the imprint of authority receives greater recognition than a person's name. The relationship between spoken orders and a symbolic signature is unsettling in literary terms: the person responsible becomes indistinct, while the effect of the command remains visible. Meera nevertheless makes clear that identifying the mark and establishing authorship of each document must be undertaken as separate inquiries.

Mahavir's Ignorance and Haricharan's Resistance

Mahavir is shaken on seeing what has been concealed within the prestige of his family. Haricharan, by contrast, immediately defends himself with the claim that "being a witness is not a crime." The opposing responses leave the reader with an open question: how much of the ignorance was genuine, and how much was convenient? Objects discovered in the chest alter the meaning of both men's memories. The narrator does not, however, accept Mahavir's remorse as proof of innocence. The events bring into view a natural distinction between "obtaining consent" and "persuading someone to consent." Even after the upper room has been

emptied, the work of a public hearing before the village remains unfinished.

Critical Section 259 | Original Chapter 158 — Comparing the Consent Notebook

Consent Is Not a Fact but a Statement Tested Against Experience

The consent notebook, safeguarded throughout the night, is opened the following morning in the presence of the families' voices. Meera stops the rush to read names aloud at a public gathering. First there must be separate testimony from the families, then comparison with the documents, followed by a list of discrepancies and a collective hearing. Through this sequence the narrator places the plurality of human experience against the singular voice of an official document. A word as easily written as "voluntary" repeatedly proves incompatible with the actual circumstances of rain, illness, hunger, and fear. The chief drama lies not in a court's decision but in the families' long replies to short lines on paper.

Rampari's Statement: A Night of Illness and Pressure on a Thumb

Rampari, Kailash's elder sister, says that her father did receive medicine, but there was no discussion of the land dispute that night. People from the ashram urged the family to write of Baba's grace and held a hand to obtain a thumb impression. In the consent notebook the event appears under the words "voluntary silence." The contrast between the statements is sharp. The family was thankful for treatment, but a free decision to relinquish a land claim was never part of what occurred during that night of illness. Instead of offering a general declaration of moral outrage, the author establishes a distance between one specific night and the permanent sentence entered upon paper.

Sakuni's Old Water Pot and the Panchayat Promise

Sakuni brings her mother's old water pot and a torn sack that once held grain. When these objects of relief are placed beside the memory of being prevented from speaking in the panchayat, the meaning of the notebook's phrase "panchayat promise" changes. Sakuni's mother remained silent; the paper turned her silence into a promise. This is a forced transformation of speech in which a statement never made by a person is manufactured as that person's written declaration. The old water pot does not independently disprove the purported consent. It does, however, preserve the living circumstances of the silence. The author allows a victim's domestic belongings to enter the collective rereading of memory.

Phoolkali's Blanket: From Refuge to a Boundary Document

Kamala brings an old blanket from the night when her grandmother sought shelter. In Sharda Jha's recollection it was raining, the roof had

collapsed, and the family stayed upon the ashram veranda; no one discussed a land dispute. The next day, a paper was taken away under the pretext of checking the relief accounts. Yet the consent notebook records a suspension of the boundary dispute. The difference between the blanket's warmth and the coldness of the field makes an especially effective visual opposition. The deeper drama is that shelter offered for protection seems to have become a shadow cast over a person's rights.

Hariballabh's Manjira and the Fabrication of a Witness's Presence

Hariballabh's father attended the kirtan to sing, not to testify on a matter of land. The notebook nevertheless records "kirtan offering, consent to presence." The observation that he could read names but not understand the procedures distinguishes literacy from knowledge of how documents are used. The author depicts the appropriation of a musician's attendance by a system that recasts it as administrative testimony. The beat of the manjira, previously associated with devotion and family life, becomes the dramatic background to an altered documentary account. The presence of an artist is not his consent to the surrender of rights unrelated to his art.

Ramlakhan's Role in "Explaining": The Language of Trust

The notebook sometimes lists Ramlakhan as a witness and sometimes as the person who "explained" the matter. He admits that even when he could see fear in people's eyes he continued to say, "Do not be frightened; put your thumb here." The significance of this conduct is that pressure need not always take the form of an open threat. Reassuring language can also surround and constrain a frightened person. Ramlakhan cannot supply every name from above, but he describes the routes by which Haricharan, the accountant, and letters from the ashram were connected. His incomplete confession gives the story moral complexity: he was both a messenger and a participant in the pressure.

Documentary Comparison and Categories of Testimony

By midday the comparison of eighteen names yields a classification: five entries indicating pressure, three converting silence into a promise, two deriving permanent claims from temporary assistance, four involving recurring witnesses, one name belonging to a deceased person, and three testimonies left incomplete. These numbers provide information while marking a new stage in the narrative. The story draws suffering seen through separate pairs of eyes into a common procedure without erasing the individual within each category. Classification is only the beginning of a conclusion. The discrepancy concerning a date of death prepares the next chapter's most disturbing inquiry.

An Undertone in the Scene and Meera's Three Distinctions

When the name of a dead person is read out, a local belief arises that white lines can be seen upon the bark of the stump. Meera does not prohibit this perception, but she has what was seen, what was believed, and what was written in the documents recorded separately. In doing so, the narrative preserves its magical-realist imagery without allowing a public accusation to depend upon a marvel. The reader may feel the emotional force of a sensory sign, but collective wonder is not granted the final standing of evidence. This two-level narrative voice is an important technique of the novel.

The Unfinished Comparison: A New Danger in the Dead Person's Name

Even after eighteen entries have been examined, the truth is not declared complete. Some testimonies remain unfinished; certain families revise their positions; Mahavir agrees to make copies of the documents from his house publicly available. The final decisive development is the possibility that consent has been recorded in the name of someone already dead. This is more than a sensational plot device. The very logic of the word "consent" is overturned when the body to which it refers is no longer present. The next critical section tests this discrepancy through chronology, the form of signatures, and the marks denoting rights to make copies.

Critical Section 260 | Original Chapter 159 — The Consent of the Dead

The Contradiction of Consent After Death and a Terrifying Narrative Thread

An inconsistent entry from Chapter 158 now becomes the subject of a separate investigation. The date on Jagdish Mahto's consent document differs by twenty days from the date recorded in the death register. The author confronts the end of a life with the artificial continued presence created by paperwork. Recording a dead person's consent is not the revival of a soul; it becomes the continuation, even after death, of the misuse of social rights. Where earlier chapters sought to restore lost names, here the perpetrators make a dead person's name appear to be unlawfully "living." This reversal has a profound relationship with the novel's title and its motif of water burial.

Parmanand's Recollection and Four Markers of Time

The account of the death of Jagdish's father is given firmer substance through Parmanand's recollection, the death register, the time of the shraddha rites, and the neighbours' statements. Meera does not turn one memory into an immediate final judgment. She compares four independent temporal markers. In this narrative arrangement a trembling recollection and a registered date remain different kinds of source. The reader encounters the ethical force of personal grief while also recognising the necessity of factual chronological testing. The novel maintains both modes of reading at once.

Sona Jha's Absence: The Geographical Distance of the Body

The consent notebook records Sona Jha as present at the ashram, while a letter from her son Harinarayan places her in Kashi, incapacitated by a wound to her foot. A letter from a distant city and an entry bearing the same date in the village notebook form a literary collision. The person is alive, but her body is in one place while the document makes her stand in another. This conflicting presence shows that a name may be appropriated without its owner having died. The author extends the chapter's title, "The Consent of the Dead," into the wider problem of fabricated attendance by the living.

Rukmini Devi's Signature: Reading Handwriting as Embodied Practice

Rukmini Devi was educated and had a familiar, rounded style of handwriting. The hard strokes in the consent notebook do not resemble

it. Her niece Sharda brings an authentic old letter, and the visual comparison of the two signatures upon a glass board enables the author to describe writing as a trace of bodily habit, movement, and force. Nevertheless, the novel's conjecture about a "man's hand" should not be mistaken for a definitive finding of forensic handwriting analysis. A concrete comparison opens a path towards evidence; a generalisation about personal writing style is not sufficient to determine guilt.

The Cut-Out Page of the Register of Rights Notices

A box brought from Mahavir's house contains the donation register, the service ledger, and a volume of "Rights Notices." Batuknath appears on its first page, Haricharan's handwriting on the second, and the accountant's figures on the third; the following page has been cut away. The drama of this vacant space is important. The damaged volume becomes another "absent" character in its own right. The narrator treats the gap as a possible site of falsification but does not supply imagined contents for the missing page. The reader is made to experience the meaning of an absence without being given certainty about what it concealed.

Three Forms of the Seal: Donation, Service, and Rights

Devika notices a similar emblem in the consent notebook, the service ledger, and the register of rights notices. Compassion in donation, indebtedness through service, and pressure upon rights are gathered into three layers of a single visual symbol. The recurrence of the mark draws extensive social relationships into the image of one object. What had been accepted as a mark of trust might also have functioned as an instrument for transferring rights. This ambiguity prevents the seal from being mere ornament attached to a conventional villain; it becomes a central narrative object linking language, institutions, and the manufacture of assent.

The "Shadow Seal" and the Birthmark of a Copy

Bhanu Lal's bag contains trial impressions of a duplicate seal and an iron stamp. One corner of its half-moon figure is slightly crooked. Similar crooked corners appear on some pages purporting to record the consent of deceased persons. The author turns the deception implicit in an "almost identical" impression into a finely observed visual detail. The characters' practice of preserving different impressions for comparison supplies material suspense. Yet the question of whose hand applied any particular mark, and when, remains unanswered. Meera calls this a possible sign of copying, not a complete finding of criminal responsibility.

Threads Leading to the Warehouse: A Visual Map of Beneficiaries

The subsequent purchasers of land recorded in the names of dead or absent people turn out to include Chandrapal's nephew, the accountant's brother-in-law, and one of Lau's partners. Aruni stretches red thread between the names, with all the lines converging upon the old warehouse. Through this pictorial device, dispersed archival entries acquire a common focal point. Chandrapal's direct signature has not been found, but the movement of benefits leads towards his commercial sphere. The material map intensifies the suspense while holding back any judicial conclusion.

The List of Nine Pages and Multiple Kinds of Irregularity

Among nine pages involving the purported consent of deceased persons, the text classifies three as bearing copied seal marks, two as containing impossible dates, two as placing absent bodies at a location, one as relying on a false witness, and one as retaining the trace of a cut sheet. The reader encounters not one uniform method of wrongdoing but several possible instruments. Their variety makes the narrative scheme appear organised, although the circumstances of each page still need separate examination. The numbers give the story's fear a concrete shape; they cannot substitute for a complete determination of guilt.

A Contradiction with Earlier Accounts of Bhanu Lal's Presence

In this chapter Bhanu Lal personally arrives carrying an old bag and speaks about copied seal impressions. In several preceding chapters, however, statements attributed to his son Ramesh Muhariya present the father as a figure belonging to an earlier period, whose surviving registers and seal-making materials remain available. The text provides no clear transition in time or explanation of Bhanu Lal's living or deceased status between these indirect recollections and his present direct appearance. It would be improper to assume that he has entered as a symbolic ghost. The criticism should register this as an inconsistency in the construction of personal chronology rather than alter the original story.

Conclusion: The Dead Demand the Restoration of Their Rights

To make a dead person's name appear in a forged document is, indirectly, to steal even from death. At the chapter's close the village does not proclaim an instant victory. The notebook's contents indicate possible routes by which benefits moved. The narrative of truth is therefore an attempt to reconnect documents with the correct persons and times, rather than to destroy the documents. On this ethical and formal basis the following chapter enters the warehouse, where objects possibly connected with the manufacture of false seals, transactions, and instructions will be sought.

Critical Section 261 | Original Chapter 160 — The Shadow of the Warehouse

From the Village Map to the Actual Threshold of the Warehouse

The pages purporting to record the consent of the dead, and the lines of the land-purchase deeds, converged towards the old warehouse. Chapter 160 turns this visual map into a journey actually undertaken by the characters. Meera, Ananya, Aruni, Devika, Satyavrat, Bhikhari Lal, Ramlakhan and other witnesses proceed towards the building. The movement changes the direction of events in the novel: after examining records beside the stump, the group now opens the door of a possible centre of material operations belonging to the opposing side. Yet Meera prevents mob violence even before they arrive. The momentum of reaching a suspenseful place and the restraint imposed by precaution advance together.

The Warehouse Key and Dhiru's Statement

Dhiru, the warehouse caretaker, says that Lau Sahib told him to keep the key and that the goods were said to belong to Chandrapal. The chain of custody of the key becomes the narrative's first specific link: where an object was kept, in whose trust, and under whose name. This brief exchange matters because Chandrapal is not himself present, yet his commercial 'shadow' begins to acquire solidity through another person's words. Dhiru's statement is testimony; the ledger, maps and other materials relating to movement in and out of the building are examined separately in order to verify it.

The Wall Map and the Earlier Red Thread

Field boundaries appear on the warehouse wall in several colours, accompanied by marks, dots and crosses. Aruni compares them with the map made from red thread beneath the stump. The scene uses the narrative procedure of 'an imagined connection first, a concrete spatial correspondence afterwards'. Readers now reread the earlier map from a new perspective. Lines coinciding at the same mark strengthen the connection, but who made the wall map, and when, remain questions for inquiry.

The 'Shadow Seal' in the Warehouse Ledger

The reference to a 'shadow seal' inside the warehouse ledger gives a commercial vocabulary to the earlier suspicion that marks of authority had been copied. The procedure of recording page numbers, dates, names and observations separately becomes the narrative rhythm of this search

among objects. Shadow is no longer merely an image of a ghost or a memory; it becomes a technical term for the reproduction of a seal and a system of profit. Through this widening of meaning, the novel's magical symbol and the deceit of the marketplace meet inside a single expression.

'Elderly', 'Widow', 'Dead': Classifying the Targets

Some of the labels and materials found in the warehouse bear no complete personal names, only designations such as 'elderly', 'widow', 'distant' and 'ill'. This classification links the story with an established pattern of digital fraud: the criminal first reduces a person to a single word identifying vulnerability. The village register had restored rights by giving people their full names; the warehouse list diminishes them into categories of risk. This direct opposition between two languages of record-keeping is a central ethical and formal achievement of the novel.

'Oral Instructions' in a Coat Pocket

A slip of paper is found in the pocket of a coat hanging in the rear room of the warehouse. It says that the page concerning Chandrapal Babu's oral instructions must not go outside; Lau's small signature appears below. The object reveals a contradiction between an oral instruction and its written reference. An order supposedly not to be placed on paper has itself survived in paper form. The narrative irony is sharp. Nevertheless, the contents of the slip and the correspondence of its signature and date remain matters for investigation within the story; they must not immediately be treated as a final determination of guilt.

Laughter Inside, Weeping Outside: A Division of Perspective

Dhiru says that meetings inside concerned donations, loans, boundaries and 'intermediary expenses', and that laughter could be heard there, while people outside wept. The auditory contrast between these places constitutes the author's socio-spatial criticism. The wall between wealthy, secretive dealings inside and vulnerable people waiting outside is visible, yet conceals their mutual relationship. The metaphor of the warehouse as 'the ear of crime' emerges in Satyavrat's admission. What he failed to hear on the veranda of the old court returns as an exercise in a character's self-examination.

The Triangle of Original, Copy and the Dead Person's Page

The comparison of an impression obtained from the warehouse with the original mark of authority and the earlier page concerning a dead person culminates a lengthy investigation. The tiny points, the angle of the crescent and the pressure of the three impressions are examined. Here the author elevates a mechanical object to the status of a narrative 'character':

the difference is minute, but its consequences for fields and homes are immense. Yet identifying the beneficiary of a crime from physical similarities is another stage of inquiry. Meera therefore restricts what is announced: comparable material has been found, not a final conclusion.

Satyavrat's Trembling and Mahavir's Public Account

The scene inside the warehouse recalls to Satyavrat his earlier failure to listen. His trembling does not establish an emotional hierarchy; it registers the memory of complicit silence. Mahavir declares that a public accounting will be made of the marks of authority held by his household. The actions of these two elderly characters differ: one acknowledges responsibility for an earlier judicial silence, while the other relinquishes private control over family emblems. Neither act of repentance automatically repairs the old injuries. The objects must still be safeguarded, and the subsequent investigation must continue.

Chandrapal's Absence After the Warehouse Is Opened

After the warehouse is opened, Chandrapal's name is spoken again in the village, but he does not appear before the group. Through the lines of profit, the caretaker's statement, Lau's signature and the objects in the building, the narrative gives bodily shape to the influence of an absent, powerful character. This presence at a distance is part of the author's strategy of delayed disclosure. It is not complete anonymity, however: the name has become a public question. In the following chapter, threats delivered by telephone will transform that question through a new medium, carrying fear from office papers into the private ear.

Critical Section 262 | Original Chapter 161 — Captive on the Telephone

From the Warehouse Lock to the Lock of a Voice

After the iron lock of the warehouse has been opened, Chapter 161 brings an elderly litigant to the stump carrying an old push-button telephone. He says that he has been imprisoned inside the telephone. The image of physical confinement is transformed into a new communications medium. The power of seals and files now speaks inside the ear. The direction of the plot also turns: whereas the investigation was organised at a communal site, an isolated individual is terrorised at night. The author thus relocates the centre of crime from the warehouse to a telephone inside the home, where it assumes a new form.

The Voice of Authority: Counterfeit Official Language

An unfamiliar voice on the telephone claims to be connected with an inquiry, a court or security authorities. It threatens a supposedly secure account, the sealing of the house, the arrest of the man's son and the public disclosure of his name. The construction of this dialogue is significant: the vocabulary of threat is dressed in the costume of authority. The criminal does not appear; a manufactured voice impresses an institutional seal upon the listener's judgment. The elderly litigant trusts it because it knows a name and a case number he regards as confidential. In fact, the possible leakage of that information opens the story's next line of inquiry.

Half the Money Is Gone: The Discomfort of a Belated Rescue

The man's grandson reports that half the money has already been transferred; he prevented the remainder from being sent. This detail prevents the story from offering an easy resolution between right and wrong. The community begins to decode the language of fear, but the loss has already occurred. The grandson's role emerges through dialogue between generations. The young member of the family is not merely someone who operates technical devices: he supports an elder whom fear has left isolated. In this partial rescue, the consequences of crime and the beginnings of collective awareness unfold together.

A Number from Inside the File on the Telephone: The Question of a Records Leak

The threatening voice knows the elderly litigant's case number and details concerning the discarded sack. Satyavrat and Bhikhari Lal connect this

knowledge with a possible leak from the records office. The story develops a new chain: confidential information in a file, credibility acquired over the telephone, and money transferred from a bank account. The actual route of the leak, however, has not been established; the access of everyone who might be implicated remains to be compared. The frightening possibility that official information has entered a criminal script intensifies the narrative.

'Tell No One': An Instruction to Remain Alone

The caller demands not only money but also the isolation of the elderly man. 'Tell no one' is a distinctive technique of speech: first sever relationships, then intensify fear, and finally invoke the language of a 'safe' transfer. Contrary to the collective campaign to safeguard names, this command to secrecy seeks to leave the individual without a witness. Precisely by reversing that command, Meera formulates the chapter's civic response: the voice of fear must reach other ears. The author makes it possible to read a technical fraud as a structure of social isolation.

The Old Push-Button Telephone: The Choice of an Object

Instead of a gleaming modern screen, the author shows the worn push-button telephone belonging to the elderly man. This choice simultaneously reveals the character's limited resources, generational distance and disposition to trust a voice. The machinery of falsehood does not depend solely upon the spectacle of new technology: even an ordinary ring from an old telephone can frighten someone into becoming the means by which property is taken. The telephone arrives at the stump together with the tremor of the man's body. In the next chapter this object will be placed upon a communal table for collective reading.

A New Habitat for the Crocodile Metaphor

In earlier chapters the crocodile had appeared symbolically in water, a discarded sack, seals and the warehouse darkness. Here it becomes the trap of a voice on the telephone. This is not simply the relocation of a name. The crocodile's narrative method of isolating its prey parallels the secrecy of the fraud. When describing the social roots of digital deception, the author makes no primary claim about the actual biological behaviour of crocodiles; the creature remains a literary symbol of terrifying consumption.

The Elderly Man's Shame and the Narrator's Sympathy

Having lost money, the elderly litigant cannot at first bring himself to speak; his grandson answers for him. The novel elicits compassion without reducing the man to a helpless object: he himself supplies the expression

that he has been held captive by the telephone. The victim's dignity lies in this act of naming his own experience. The group's response is not punitive ridicule but preparation to dissect the language of crime. Even as the narrative examines the machinery of fraud, it prevents the victim's shame from becoming a silent accomplice to that machinery.

Final Scene: From Private Fear to a Collective Reading

The chapter closes by looking towards a gathering that will analyse the technique of threatening calls. The elderly man's trembling hand becomes material for a new school of learning. Neither has the fraudster been arrested nor has the missing money been recovered; the achievement is that one person's unspoken fear has become a social question. With this incomplete answer, the author leads the reader into the next chapter, 'The Seal of the Voice', where the imitation of authority will itself be heard as an object of collective reading.

Critical Section 263 | Original Chapter 162 — The Seal of the Voice

The Authority of a Voice: A Parallel to the Seal on Paper

At the opening of the chapter Meera explains that a voice, like a seal on paper, demands recognition as an authority. Phrases such as 'I am calling from the court', 'from the bank' or 'from the police station' influence the listener's judgment before anything has been established. The narrative identifies this performance of power as a 'counterfeit of trust'. In the preceding chapter, sound generated fear in isolation; here fragments of recorded speech are replayed before different people. Through this change of setting, hearing ceases to be passive acceptance and becomes an active critical practice.

Many Telephones, One Method: Multiple Voices and a Uniform Script

The children bring information about telephone calls received in different homes into a single register. They create columns for numbers, times, names spoken, sums demanded, phrases intended to frighten and the responses given. The voices claiming to represent the electricity department, a bank, the police station and the court sound different, but their sequence—trust, threat, haste and isolation—is much the same. Through this repetition the novel reveals the counterfeit voices as an organised script. Each victim's experience is private, while the structure of the language is collective; this doubleness allows the reader to recognise a dangerous conspiracy rather than dwell on individual shame.

Madhukar's Entry Register: A Cover of Three Names

The records-office entry register shows Madhukar entering three times under different connections: on Lau's recommendation, with Haricharan's papers, and as a representative of Chandrapal. One individual assumes several roles. In the novel's theatrical chapters, performance had served as testimony to truth; in the criminal's multiplicity of disguises, performance turns other people's vulnerability into private gain. Reconciling the dates of the three entries carries the story from theatrical language to tangible institutional records of movement. An entry register, however, does not by itself prove every criminal act imagined in connection with those visits.

Sakuni's Eyes and the Limits of What Was Seen

Sakuni states that she saw someone associated with Haricharan carrying a paper bag beside Madhukar's rented room. Meera immediately instructs

her to record only what she saw, not the conclusion she might draw. This moment does not diminish her credibility; it increases it. Testimony becomes clearer to the reader when a witness recognises the limits of her own observation. The narrator develops Sakuni from a woman who had been silenced into an attentive, active observer. Even when an act of seeing becomes public speech, the space occupied by unanswered questions remains protected.

The Calendar in the Rented Room: Dates as a List of Targets

Three dates ringed in red on a calendar in Madhukar's room correspond to entries in the access register. Below them, the four terms 'elderly', 'son abroad', 'field' and 'account' reduce human lives to a terrifyingly narrow set of particulars. Where the village register restores names and family relationships, the fraudulent operation breaks people into vulnerable points that can be exploited. Through these opposing archival practices the novel effectively demonstrates the social need for a 'vigil over names'.

Rehearsed Voices on the Recorder: The Inverse Use of Theatre

A cheap recorder found beneath the bed contains rehearsed voices invoking an investigative branch, a secure account and the threat of arrest. Different speakers deliver the same sentences according to one script. Devika calls this a misuse of performance. The story establishes a disturbing parallel between the performance that enabled witnesses to speak at the earlier Videha Theatre Festival and the performance now used to deceive. The technique of acting has no intrinsic ethical character: its significance depends on whose life it protects, or whose fear it sells.

Three Transfers of Money and the Name 'M. Prasad'

Information arrives from the bank that half the elderly litigant's money has been divided into three small transfers. One identifier is false, another belongs to a dead person, and a third appears as 'M. Prasad Service Centre'. The plot thereby connects the warehouse's documents of consent attributed to the dead with telephone fraud through a further narrative channel. But the initial 'M' does not conclusively identify Madhukar; it poses a question about a possible route of transfer. The author produces suspense from the instability of reference. Greater caution is needed precisely so that justice is not lost in an infatuation with a single letter.

Haricharan's Quiet Call: Words Heard, Source Unresolved

Sakuni hears Haricharan move away from the crowd and say 'remove the papers' during a quiet telephone call. She does not shout this as a rumour at the gathering; she tells Meera privately what she heard. In the register, the source is specified as 'heard by Sakuni'. This entry propels the mystery into

the next chapter, but the identity of the papers, who would remove them and the purpose remain unknown. An accurate narratological reading must keep the dramatic force of the dialogue distinct from the uncertainties of the facts it may imply.

A Public Reading of Fear: The Sharing of Ears

At night the elderly people themselves read out the threatening phrases. The children then identify each mechanism: pressure of time, isolation, impersonation of an officer, threatened disgrace and the demand for a 'secure' transfer of money. What seemed decisive when heard yesterday by a solitary person is recognised, in company, as an ordinary prepared script. Narrative form becomes a kind of remedial practice: repetition is employed not to magnify fear but to expose its construction. Collective listening becomes an active civic exercise within the world of the novel.

Two Uncertain Futures: Madhukar Missing, the Order to Remove Papers

At the end of the chapter Madhukar has not been found, Haricharan's connection remains uncertain, Chandrapal's name enters only indirectly, and the intended object of 'remove the papers' is unidentified. Nevertheless, a decision to preserve copies in four separate places provides a response to that fear. This ending is not a complete revelation of the mystery; it is an arrangement to safeguard sources after a risk has been recognised. The narrator holds excitement and restraint together, giving the next chapter a natural reason to search for traces of removed documents.

Critical Section 264 | Original Chapter 163 — Traces of the Removed Papers

From 'Remove the Papers' to Dawn in the Records Office

The incomplete instruction heard by Sakuni leaves a mystery at the end of the preceding chapter. Chapter 163 searches the records office at dawn for the possible consequences of that instruction. Through the movement of a bird's wings, dust on the cupboards and the description of an exposed space, the narrator shows the reader visual details left after an event. This proximity in time—the words spoken at night and the empty place discovered in the morning—creates narrative tension, but does not establish who entered the office or when. The story observes traces first and seeks answers afterwards.

Cupboard Number Seventeen: Footprints in Dust

Marks resembling those of bare feet or soft slippers appear in the dust before the cupboard. Following Meera's instruction, Ananya immediately puts a question mark beside this first conjecture. The pause matters: the visible material can be described, but its explanations may be multiple. In metaphor, the dust becomes an 'old clerk', yet in the register it cannot serve as a conclusive witness identifying a person. A magical figure of speech and careful observation proceed side by side.

Measuring an Empty Shelf: The Body of an Absent Object

After a file is found missing, the children record the length and width of the vacant space, the colour of its cord and a dried fragment of glue. The absence of the object becomes a visible arrangement in its own right. Earlier the novel represented the absence of names belonging to unnamed people through stones and blank pages; here the place of an absent file raises questions. This returning metaphor performs a new function, moving from poetic mourning towards the discipline of inspection. Measurement is not the complete answer: it merely indicates the possible dimensions of a missing object.

Parmanand's Statement: Delimiting Responsibility through an Employee's Presence

The older clerk's expression changes when the new clerk Parmanand is mentioned. Parmanand admits that he was made to open the door in the name of orders from above. Such an order might have come through someone associated with Haricharan or by telephone in the name of Chandrapal's office. He was handed a bag but did not see what it

contained. His admission contains both responsibility for an act and a limit to what he knows. He does not conceal that he may have facilitated improper access, but neither does he claim to have seen the missing file. The reader encounters the experience of an incomplete intermediary rather than that of someone who knows the entire network.

The Impression on the Back of Carbon Paper: The Written Memory of Pressure

On carbon paper caught behind cupboard seventeen appear reversed and incomplete impressions of the phrases 'death certificate attached', 'heir absent' and 'mortgage re-verification'. Carbon paper does not itself originate the letters: it takes an impression from the pressure applied to another page. The author turns this material characteristic into an ethical metaphor. The exploited body bears pressure and retains its history. Carbon cannot disclose all the truth in the absence of the original, but it can preserve a genuine direction for inquiry.

A 'Death Certificate' for the Living Nageshwar

When Nageshwar Jha's name emerges from the indistinct carbon impression, the elderly litigant says that the man is alive, though ill. Satyavrat cautions that recording a living person as dead can redirect the course of landholding, inheritance and banking transactions. The scene reverses the practice of obtaining consent in the names of the dead in Chapter 159: here someone appears to be trying to turn the living into the dead. The narrative joins the written substitution of death for life to the threat of property transfer. Testimony from Nageshwar's home is still necessary for confirmation.

The Visit to Nageshwar's House: A Living Body Resisting Paper

Sakuni visits Nageshwar at home. Lying unwell on a cot, the elderly man hears his name and makes the simple assertion that he is alive. His breathing, the papers preserved by his wife and his memory of the leaves form an utterly ordinary yet decisive domestic scene. Against the word 'dead' in the file stands the bodily presence of a living person on his cot: this is the story's sharpest opposition. But his sick body must not be turned into a public spectacle. The characters carry away what they have heard within the delicate privacy of the household and do so cautiously.

'M. Prasad Service': Small Deductions from Meaning and Money

The name 'M. Prasad Service' appears in the carbon impression. Later information suggests that it refers not to a local account but to an external payment facility, through which small sums are repeatedly transferred away. The author connects the documentary network and the narrative of

fear over the telephone through this financial process. The crocodile's devouring here consists not of one savage bite but of taking a little on each occasion. It would be improper to attach the name automatically to Madhukar or anyone else, because the full identity of the account holder has not yet been established.

Haricharan's Absence: Recorded Fact and Spoken Rumour

Haricharan is absent from the meeting that day. Villagers circulate several explanations for his failure to attend: anger, fear or some other business. Meera enters none of these explanations into the record, having only 'Haricharan absent' written down. With this small sentence the novel sets a limit upon communal narration. A name and an absence constitute one fact; the meaning of that absence is a separate interpretation. There is already grave suspicion surrounding the man heard saying 'remove the papers', but no additional conjecture about the cause of his absence is recorded as fact.

The Crocodile, Carbon and Torn Paper in a Single Scene

Towards the end, a crocodile appears at the riverbank, half in the water and half in the mud. Lines on its skin seem to resemble the torn edges of paper. This magical scene returns the carbon impression, the missing page and the theft of life to the novel's foundational symbol of water. The author does not establish as fact that a crocodile actually ate the papers. Rather, the characters' comparison allows the reader to experience the possibility that names cannot finally be erased. The protection of sources and the terrifying force of nature coexist in this symbol.

Interim Conclusion: A New Person behind the Missing Page

At the chapter's end the full contents of the removed document have not been recovered. What has been brought together consists of Nageshwar Jha's statement, the carbon impression, Parmanand's incomplete admission and information about an external payment channel. After each discovery the author opens the threshold of another person's life. What began as a dispute about an unnamed file becomes urgent when attached to a living elder's name. The novel thus prevents its prolonged archival passages from degenerating into a passive collection of papers: every document ultimately reaches questions of bodily rights and the vulnerability of a home.

Inter-Sectional Discussion: From the Debt of Charity to the Removed Papers

Across Critical Sections 257–264, the narrative forms a deep causal line running from the memory of charity to a fabricated death certificate for a

living person. At first the moral debt of charity leaves a hand half-raised; the iron chest reveals the written organisation of that silence; the consent notebook is compared with actual human lives; and the falsehood of obtaining consent in the names of the dead comes to light. The warehouse then indicates a possible route of profit, the counterfeit voice of authority on the telephone reaches an elder's bank account, the seal of that voice is broken by collective listening, and the carbon impression left behind by a page removed from the records office brings new testimony. Through this progression the story moves from asking who owns 'the written sentence' to asking who owns 'the spoken sentence'.

Across the eight chapters, the order of objects lends meaning to each successive object. The half-raised hand, Nirmala's water pot, the cymbals of the devotional singing, the key to the prayer room, the iron chest, the thumbprint pad, Kamala's blanket, the severed page of an authority notice, the crescent of a seal, the red thread of the warehouse, the old push-button telephone, the calendar in the rented room, the recorder, cupboard seventeen and the black carbon impression all serve as consecutive carriers of the story. The author renders abstract exploitation in these small, tangible objects. Every new object requires the reader to reread the story of earlier objects. The cymbals no longer signify devotion alone; the ledger wrapped in cloth no longer signifies service alone; the telephone no longer signifies information alone. The transformation of the meanings of objects is the chief formal force of this sequence.

In the organisation of characters, the voices of victims and intermediaries perform different functions. Kailash, Sakuni, Hariballabh, Rampari, Kamala, Jagmaya, Surmani, Nageshwar and the elderly litigant test the one-sided assertions of records against memories preserved in their homes. Statements by Ramlakhan, Bhikhari Lal, Mahavir, Bhanu Lal, Kailash Prasad, Dhiru and Parmanand illuminate different stages of administrative mediation. Meera restrains the rush to make public accusations; Ananya maintains the investigative register; Devika rereads meaning and language; Aruni compares objects and dates; Satyavrat remains caught between an earlier silence and present responsibility. Within this polyphony, no single character occupies the final seat of an all-knowing judge.

The temporal organisation of the chapters shifts from waiting towards the dates associated with crime. A night of illness and a later land claim, a rainy night and a postponed boundary decision, a date of consent and a date of death, a letter showing residence in Kashi and a purported presence at the ashram, nocturnal warehouse meetings and three small bank transfers: these are discrepant layers of time. The source of literary suspense here is not immediately 'Who is the criminal?' but 'How can the times

recorded on two pages both be possible?' A dead person is represented as living and giving consent; a plan appears to place the living Nageshwar under the authority of a death certificate. In these reciprocal inversions, the relationship between name and body assumes a new form of the novel's central tragedy.

The new events involving communication produce an important echo of the earlier Videha Theatre Festival. There, kabaddi players had used performance to make suppressed stories publicly audible; here, in Madhukar's room, official voices are rehearsed on a recorder and telephone to frighten people in isolation. The technique of acting can be the same, but the relationship in which it operates differs: whose consent, whose payment, whose silence? Through this inversion the author does not grant theatrical technique automatic moral innocence; its meaning emerges from the circumstances of its use. The collective reading that separates the phrases of fear in a register is a kind of counter-performance against the performance of deception.

Respect for uncertainty about sources is a significant feature of this sequence. New folds in old papers, marks in the consent notebook, impossible dates, conflicting accounts of presence, the slanting corner of a seal, a slip found in the warehouse, Sakuni's report of hearing 'remove the papers', dust marks at cupboard seventeen, Parmanand's statement and the reference to 'M. Prasad' are entered separately. The characters repeatedly distinguish the discovery of an indication, a family's memory, comparison of dates and final determination of criminal responsibility. Consequently, even as the story becomes a legal thriller, it tries to avoid announcing punishment before investigation. At the same time, moments when a gesture or a smell is treated as approaching certain truth remain a critical risk in its narrative method.

There is a noteworthy contradiction in the chronology of Bhanu Lal's character. Earlier passages describe the remaining materials and traditions associated with Bhanu Lal, father of Ramesh Muhariya, giving the reader the impression that the father belongs to the past. Yet in this sequence Bhanu Lal himself arrives carrying a bag and discusses the use of copied seals. The original narrative does not explain clearly whether this is an event in his living present, an image of memory or a supernatural appearance. It must therefore be identified as a textual inconsistency. The reader should not impose an invented death or revival in order to manufacture coherence. The uncertainty about his temporal status matters to the reader's trust.

The final achievement of this sequence is neither Chandrapal's arrest nor the restoration of property belonging to the dead, nor the full recovery of the elderly litigant's money. Its achievement is that separate systems of

deception involving documents and voices become visible as related; an arrangement to safeguard sources in four places begins; and the living body of Nageshwar openly challenges the word 'dead' on paper. The magical image of the crocodile in the water does not create an illusion that this unfinished justice has already been concluded. The narrative shows that restoring a person's name demands time, permission, family memory, sensitive reading and sustained work towards accountability. The following chapters open the possibility of showing both the results of this continuing inquiry and new forms of resistance.

Critical Section 265 | Original Chapter 164 — The Belly of Chandrapal's Shadow

The Return of "17/C": From a Missing Page to a Structural Link

The seventeenth cupboard, the removed papers and the reversed carbon impression from the preceding chapter converge at this chapter's opening in the abbreviated sign "17/C." The number is not itself an answer; it indicates a possible relationship among otherwise separate events. Ananya has kept it in mind throughout the night, as though a small mark on a document could open the next door of the plot. The author advances the mystery not by suddenly introducing a criminal but by recombining scenes already encountered. The reader must activate memory, since every earlier scene now becomes available for reinterpretation.

The Network Speaking in Sequence: Satyavrat's Five Objects

Satyavrat places five things in order: Parmanand's statement, the vacant place in the cupboard, the carbon impression of a "death certificate," the name "M. Prasad Seva," and "17/C." They belong to five distinct languages: oral admission, material absence, a written imprint, an institutional name and a numerical indication. Their difference makes the novel's archival narrative multilayered. No one item automatically proves another; nevertheless, their sequence gives a new shape to the questions. The narrative shows the reader a possible relationship, not a verdict upon the events.

The "C" of the Cupboard and the C-Room: A Double Sign

In the court's internal classification of records, section C is said to concern disputed inheritances and mortgages; Parmanand recalls hearing "section C" on the telephone. A C-room then appears in Chandrapal's office. The recurrence of one letter in places inside and outside the court provides a bridge for suspicion. The repetition is meaningful, but it would be premature to conclude that the two instances of C belong to a single system. Through Ananya and Aruni, the narration keeps both possibilities available and leaves the source of the "inside information" uncertain.

Parmanand's Trembling Palm: The Focalisation of Fear

When Parmanand is offered a seat instead of being scolded, his account becomes clearer. The heavy voice on the telephone, the whispering behind it and the instruction concerning a bag survive in his memory only as fragments. The reader therefore apprehends the network not through an omniscient view of the complete scheme but through the limited hearing of a frightened subordinate employee. Under such restricted focalisation,

silence need not amount to an admission of guilt. His trembling evokes both metaphorical fear and the unreliability of recollection; Meera resists the haste to attach a definite criminal to his testimony.

The Language of the Service List: A Polished Cover for Teeth

The signboard outside Chandrapal's office gleams; inside, the advertised services include help with pensions, banking facilities, inheritance and land records. Materially, this is an ordinary service office. Yet readers who remember the earlier list of elderly victims can perceive in the same terms possible avenues for selecting prey. The author constructs a contrast between the peeling paint of the outer gate and the shining promises within. This description does not establish a crime; the apprehension that the vocabulary of service is being misused generates the narrative tension. The scene shows how words associated with social trust can become terrifying objects in a story.

Nageshwar's Receipt: The Body of the Home and the Office Seal

An old receipt sent by Nageshwar Jha's wife carries the stamp "Chandrapal Counselling Centre." A receipt emerging from the home of a living man who might have been rendered dead on paper establishes a possible connection with the office. Domestic recollection here is not opposed to the court's carbon impression; it offers a complementary route towards understanding it. Nevertheless, the receipt cannot be treated as final proof of a criminal transaction. Meera's and Satyavrat's conduct at precisely this limit sustains the caution of the narrative design.

The Envelope Marked "M. Prasad Seva": The Mystery of Location

An empty envelope printed with "M. Prasad Seva" is discovered in a drawer in the office's C-room. The name previously associated with an external payment now takes the physical form of paper. Its recurrence exemplifies narrative return: a sign from a digital account reappears as an envelope. An employee tries to dismiss it as the material of an "outside agency," but that answer creates a new question: why was the envelope in an internal drawer? The mismatch between words and location prevents an easy identification and keeps the reader on the path of inquiry.

The Untouched Computer: Suspense in Conflict with Restraint

A partly displayed page is visible on the computer in the C-room, but nobody touches the machine without lawful authority. At a moment of heightened suspense the narrative deliberately halts action. Such a pause carries unusual dramatic force in a literary investigation of crime: even when an answer appears to be in front of one's eyes, the preservation of evidence matters. Conversely, the author does not fully clarify permission

to enter the office or the procedures formally followed. Readers may therefore question this procedural opacity. The ideal of caution and the institutional realities of the events do not receive equal elaboration at every point.

The Map of Prey: The Violence of Classification

Coloured marks on a wall designate elderly couples, sons living away from home, mortgaged land and pension accounts. This is not a map of geography so much as a possible distribution of human vulnerability. Madhukar's words in Chapter 162—"old, son away, field, account"—return here as a visual arrangement. An earlier compressed written formula becomes a visible metaphor. Surmani sees in this classification not a service scheme but a field from which prey may be gathered. Character perspective and narration reinforce each other, although any finding of individual guilt remains outstanding.

The Incomplete Revelation of the Shadow's Belly

The chapter is called "The Belly of Chandrapal's Shadow," yet it does not finally reveal the complete ownership or commanding authority of the network. The C-room, envelope, receipt and suggestions of inside knowledge converge, while Chandrapal himself remains absent. That absence gives the crocodile metaphor a further function: the network may have many mouths, but its belly suggests a possible centre. A critical question remains whether the narrator's generalisation that "the belly is never in two places" unduly reduces the polycentric nature of a complex network. The chapter's own events partly challenge that apparent certainty.

Critical Section 266 | Original Chapter 165 — The Body of the Shadow

From Shadow to Body: The Narrative Metaphor of a Search

The preceding chapter revealed the C-room in the service office; the present one asks where the material body of a shadow extending so far might be found. Instead of searching merely for a face, the story follows objects, shipments, boxes, locks and the route to a warehouse. Turning the perception of shadow into a material map is the central technique of this sequence. To call an abstract criminal network a body allows its documents to become its "bones" and fear its "breath." This poetic expansion, however, does not take the place of fact.

"17/C" and "C-17": A Narrative of Reversed Order

A box labelled C-17 appears behind the C-room, its designation reversing the order of "17/C." The author makes a minute rearrangement of signs into a small dramatic event within the mystery. Rather than immediately treating it as proof of common ownership, the reader should regard it as a possible similarity between systems of marking. The aphorism that "crime reverses numbers" is effective, but reversal in itself is no sure sign of a crime. The distance between material resemblance and the narrator's moral interpretation indicates a limit to the intended suspense.

The Geography of the Old Alley: From the Office to a Dark Passage

Behind the office's glossy list of services lies a narrow, damp alley and a rusting iron door. Moisture inside, pigeon feathers by the ventilator and wooden boxes create a world different from the office's public face. The change of setting marks a movement from formal service towards the possibility of concealed transportation. This arrangement of scenes invites inference, but the dilapidated state of the alley does not establish criminality in itself. Receipts, movements of goods and names are needed to give the suspicion substance.

Parmanand's Empty Envelope: The Paradox of Weight

Parmanand recalls that an envelope described as "empty" was nevertheless given unusual emphasis because of its weight. Surmani turns it into a metaphor for an invisible bribe. The sentence brings literal emptiness into conflict with moral weight. In literary terms the empty envelope becomes a complete object: the reader never sees its concealed contents, but that very absence intensifies imaginative suspense. This is not a finding that a bribe was actually discovered; it is a character's construction of meaning.

The Limited Reliability of the View through the Ventilator

Without legal authority to open the door at once, the group looks through a ventilator and sees the colours and codes of boxes inside. Meera opposes breaking the lock. This slows the action but also establishes the limits of visual evidence: the bolt is closed from outside, sounds within are indistinct, boxes can be seen, and their contents remain unknown. A critic should not equate this restricted view with a complete search of the premises. Dramatic suspense arises precisely because the objects remain untouched.

Reading Names Outside the Door: Reusing a Place

The gathering to read names and dates before the locked warehouse recalls an earlier hearing on the court veranda. Again and again the story transforms closed institutional doors into an open circle of public listening. The benefit of the repetition is that communal voices do not abandon the places where fear has accumulated; its limitation is that the reading cannot immediately open an actual door. The difficulties of realistic institutional time coexist with the metaphor's more immediate ethical meaning. The author leaves readers to confront the distance between them.

The Transport Receipt and the Name of Dharni Mahato

A torn transport receipt found in Madhukar's room refers to the movement of four boxes at night and to a "C warehouse." Parmanand distinguishes the office's C-room from the external warehouse, while Dharni Mahato is named as a possible transporter. This is a decisive turn in the causal sequence: the inquiry moves beyond voices towards a route of transport suggested by a document. Yet Dharni makes no statement at this point, and the crowd does not declare him guilty merely because his name has appeared.

The Weighing Scale and "Original Copy Preserved"

A small note recovered beneath the platform of an old weighing scale says that the original copy has been preserved. The object gives the reader a measure of relief: perhaps the missing original was not destroyed. The narration, however, presents this as a possibility rather than a certainty. Who wrote the note, when, and under what circumstances are questions still unanswered. The investigative method resists turning the scrap of paper into a miraculous key, even though the emotional current of the story immediately bends towards hope.

The Clue at Tetri Ghat: The Return of the River

An elderly boatman describes a possible route used to carry the boxes at night and mentions an old house and granary near Tetri Ghat. After a lengthy narrative of offices, the novel returns to the river's geography. Earlier images of crocodiles, water, landing steps, boats and mud acquire new significance in connection with the transport of documents. Meera does not enter the crocodile's gesture into the evidence register; she records only the boatman's statement. Keeping the magical scene distinct from the characters' practical decisions provides the chapter with its balance.

From a Locked Door to the Following Dawn: A Deferred Climax

At the chapter's close, night prevents the inquiry team from being dispatched immediately; they decide to visit the ghat in daylight. The postponement is not merely a device for prolonging excitement but also follows from incomplete information and questions of safety. Only the observed C-17 box, the recovered transport receipt and Dharni's name are publicly announced. The restricted disclosure shows that the narrator does not turn a new discovery into a declaration of victory. The anticipated description of the granary in the next chapter thus follows causally from this restraint.

Critical Section 267 | Original Chapter 166 — The Storehouse at Imli Ghat

Imli Ghat in the Title and Tetri Ghat in the Narrative: An Inconsistency of Place Names

The chapter is titled "The Storehouse at Imli Ghat," but in the prose the group travels towards Tetri Ghat, sees an old Tetri tree and enters a house-cum-granary at Tetri Ghat. This is not a trivial variation in spelling: Imli and Tetri are two different names, and the story does not explain why both would designate the same place. Perhaps a tree has one local name while the landing place bears another, but the original text supplies no narrative clarification of that possibility. The criticism therefore registers the inconsistency rather than arbitrarily harmonising the place names and concealing an internal difficulty of the source. Geographical precision matters in a mystery because the movement of evidence depends upon it.

From Postponement at Night to Inquiry at Dawn: Temporal Causation

In the preceding chapter Meera restrains the impulse to proceed at night and decides to visit the ghat in daylight. Dawn in this chapter is the consequence of that decision; the delay was therefore more than a device for keeping the reader curious. Wheel tracks, footprints, marks left by dragging a heavy box and a possible boat route are observed along the way to Tetri Ghat. The narrator does not conduct the search through a magical crocodile's gesture in darkness; the boatman's recollections and marks on the ground direct the plot. Moisture and footprints nevertheless do not permit the characters to date the traces precisely. Discipline in the treatment of time and an acknowledgement of uncertainty coexist in their limited observations.

The Pouch of Salt: A Practical Image of Local Experience

Surmani Devi brings a small pouch of salt; that modest object evokes the river's dampness and the vulnerability of paper to decay. The narrator does not equate her local experience with formal scientific testing: Meera regards it as partly folk knowledge and partly precaution. Consequently, salt becomes a bearer of atmosphere and local memory, not a reliable forensic instrument. The old boatman's knowledge of water, Surmani's recollection of dampness and a child's written measurements together form a culturally plural scene of observation. Embodied experience begins an inquiry; it does not constitute its final truth.

The C-17 Box: From a Repeated Sign to a Material Object

The mark glimpsed on a box through the ventilator behind Chandrapal's C-room now appears on an actual box at the ghat. Rust on its surface, a newly tied cloth strip, dried mud and fibres of paper supply four concrete details that bring the reader closer to an object, rather than a mere conjecture. Ananya records the conditions around the box before it is lifted. The technique of the mystery gradually turns a small code into something recognisable. Yet the discovery of the code does not automatically authenticate every sheet in the box. Its return repays an expectation established in the earlier chapter: readers finally see the object for which they have been waiting.

Layers of the Archive: Original, Copy and Practice Sheet

Inside the box are materials concerning Nageshwar Jha's mortgage, a draft statement attributed to Dharni Mahato and documents recording supposed consent from widows. Satyavrat expressly notes that the objects found are not all genuine originals but possible routes towards those originals. This distinction sustains the narrative's credibility: no recovered file becomes an "ultimate discovery"; instead, the successive states of original, copy, draft and practice document remain distinct. One form of paper missing from communal memory has returned, but the damage done to persons and their claims remains far from restitution. In the author's archival world, physical recovery is not judicial resolution.

Misspelt Names and the Body's Memory

Two elderly women respond to the consent documents: one says that the thumb impression could not be hers, while the other points to an incorrect spelling of her name. Their reactions show that a name is not merely a sequence of administrative letters but a living form of identity shaped by family language. The characters regard misspelling as a sign of counterfeit familiarity, although the critical limit must be maintained: not every error in a written name amounts to forgery. Here the suspicion is linked to other questionable consent documents; the spelling difference alone cannot decide culpability. The author dramatises the distance between domestic pronunciation and archival writing.

Five Red Ledgers: The Architecture of Progressive Disclosure

Five red ledgers emerge from an iron box set into an inner wall. The first lists names and payments; the second records calls, fear and isolation; the third contains codes; the fourth says "dead—ready"; and the fifth refers to a "new voice list" and a "next consignment: across the river." By opening them one by one, the author expands the alleged field of the crime: money, psychological pressure, codes, paper deaths and the prospect of a

new attack using voices. The architecture of an increasingly revealed box gives the narrative an ascending rhythm. Yet the authorship and use of each entry remain separate questions for inquiry; the ledgers are not infallible witnesses speaking for themselves.

"Dead—Ready": A Violent Script in the Future Tense

The two words "dead—ready" in the fourth ledger form one of the most disturbing brief statements in the story. Nageshwar Jha is alive, yet the possibility emerges that people like him are being designated for death in the records before death occurs. Chapter 159 showed consent being attributed to people already dead; here a living person's future paper death appears to be arranged. The two inversions create a larger tragedy: an attempt to declare the time of documents independent of biological time. The crocodile's devouring acquires the meaning of taking a life through letters, without visible bloodshed.

Not a Measurement of Personal Weakness, but of Circumstances

A plastic container holds documents belonging to elderly people, scraps bearing telephone details and categories such as "alone," "son abroad" and "quick to fear." Aruni first calls this a list of the elderly people's weaknesses; Meera immediately substitutes "circumstances" for "weaknesses." This small alteration of vocabulary revises the novel's perspective. The offender measures social isolation to select a target, whereas the community refuses to let a description of those circumstances become an accusation against the victim. Such focalisation separates a social problem from individual failure. The written categories remain the same, but a different reader changes their meaning.

The Voice Recorder: Foreshadowing a New Narrative Direction

A device for recording voices and practice phrases such as "tell nobody" connect the warehouse materials to the earlier episode of captivity by telephone. The plot extends from falsified land seals to a possible network of imitation voices. This development reveals the author's multimedia conception of narrative: pressure imposed through documents, voices imitated over the telephone and private information available in the marketplace are distinct carriers of the same social fear. The line "new voice list" provides a structural reason for the next journey across the river. The shift of place grows from the document's final line; it is not arbitrary.

Haricharan's Delayed Objection and the Sealed Conclusion

Haricharan calls the search unlawful only after the box has been opened. Ananya records the time of his objection; Meera's perspective connects the chronology of events with the names of those present. Yet the mere

presence of these characters does not establish that the search was legally authorised: the text does not disclose the complete chain of formal permissions or orders. This is a point at which the story's ethical discipline must be distinguished from legal procedure. Sealing the granary and preparing a public inventory furnish a dramatic conclusion, not a signal that a final sentence has been passed. The next question concerns the voice operation across the river.

The Limited Victory of the Water Metaphor

The Channa grove, river, Tetri Ghat, granary and crocodile come together again in a sequence of images. The discovery of documents and materials associated with digital intimidation in an old storehouse for grain reverses the economic life of a water-centred culture. After opening the storehouse, the people do not celebrate noisily; they measure boxes and make an inventory. The crocodile has not disappeared, and the legal standing of victims' documents has not automatically been repaired. Thus the chapter offers emotional relief while marking the limits of an interim victory. Despite the inconsistency in its place names, the causal movement from object to ghat to voice opens the following chapter.

Critical Section 268 | Original Chapter 167 — The Voice Across the River

A Journey Across the River: From Geography to an Invasion of Hearing

The fifth red ledger in the previous chapter contains the instruction “next consignment: across the river.” In this chapter the group boards a boat, and as they cross a geographical boundary an unknown telephone call enters their midst. The opposition between the boat’s slow physical movement and the telephone’s instantaneous reach gives the narration its distinctive form. The river separates one village from another, but the voice of the counterfeit official respects no border. The water image now measures the unbounded risk of communication rather than serving only as a reservoir of natural memory.

The Telephone Call on the Boat: Turning an Attempt at Control into a Public Experiment

Aruni hears “your name is under investigation” and “tell nobody” over the telephone; instead of asking him to disconnect, Meera signals that the call should be heard on the loudspeaker. The caller intends to isolate and intimidate one individual, while collective listening immediately frustrates that intention as a narrative action. Satyavrat records the time, Devika writes down the sequence of phrases and Aruni asks questions. Private terror becomes a shared laboratory for analysis. Nevertheless, hearing one call publicly is not equivalent to identifying its entire technical origin; the mystery still requires another stage of inquiry.

“Your Location Is Visible”: The Failed Performance of an All-Knowing Voice

The caller dismisses Aruni’s claim that he is on a boat as a lie and asserts that his “location” is visible. Bhikhari Lal’s familiarity with the river’s current weakens this performance of omniscience. The exchange reveals a central technique of deception: the voice pretends to know even what it does not know. When Aruni asks for his father’s name, the ensuing silence exposes the limit of that pretence. Before revealing the complete technical mystery, the author interrupts the performance at the level of language; the moment of ignorance loosens the criminal’s mask.

Madhukant and Kamala: Different Domestic Memories of Hearing

The suffering caused by a call from a counterfeit son emerges in the home of Madhukant Jha and Kamala Devi across the river. For Kamala the son’s

name and voice were sufficient to prompt immediate trust; Madhukant remembers that the real son would occasionally laugh and change the pattern of his breathing while speaking. The narrator turns this fine rhythm of family life into an emotional marker. Yet recognition of breathing is not a conclusive technical examination of recorded sound; it is the father's experience of listening. Maintaining this distinction lets readers respect the characters' experience without imposing an impossible certainty about machine-generated voices.

The Telephone's "Digital Imprisonment": The Transformation of Home

Kamala Devi had been threatened into keeping the telephone against her ear for two hours. The tulsi platform, veranda and familiar courtyard remained physically present, yet the house came to feel like a prison. The author does not lock the place in a material sense; the voice of command erects psychological walls. "Imprisonment" makes the control exercised by fear visible without a physical padlock. The story does not condemn modern communication in itself: it is when imitated trust and the language of isolation travel through a phone that a familiar home becomes unfamiliar.

Three Transfers of Money: The Economic Rhythm of the Incident

Money leaves Kamala's home in three stages: first a small sum, then a medium amount and finally the family's savings. Through this sequence the narrator presents the victim's economic losses like three blows in a drama. In the characters' interpretation, the success of the first transfer lessens suspicion about subsequent demands. Not disclosing all the sums publicly is consistent with the earlier rules of privacy. The family's loss is real, but the chapter supplies no final resolution in which the bank restores the money or the criminal is arrested. It discloses the grammar of an economic tragedy rather than its completed remedy.

Naval's Three Defences: Ignorance, a Limited Role and Distance

A young man named Naval, encountered near the veranda, first says "I know nothing," then "only the numbers," and finally "I do not manufacture voices." The changing defences of a single character provide a method of indirect characterisation. At each successive admission he attempts to diminish his own responsibility, although supplying information is necessary to the operation of the network. Meera does not immediately pronounce him fully guilty; his changing answers mark the unreliability of the account. This distinction shows that culpability cannot be understood solely by looking for the person who manufactured the voice heard on the telephone.

The Public Service Centre Computer: The Social Body of Information

At a service centre across the river, shadow copies of Aadhaar documents, pension numbers, details of migrant relatives and mobile contacts have been assembled. An implicated person calls this information "data," attempting to render the role impersonal; Satyavrat calls it the breath of families and restores its social body. This is a change of narrative naming, not merely a policy declaration. A woman once known as "Kamala Devi" becomes "mother weeps" in the offender's list; a son living elsewhere becomes a point at which pressure can be applied to extort money. The translation of individual memory into victim categories is one of the novel's most disturbing devices.

Recorder and Practice Sentences on Paper: Two Faces of Performance

Pages beside a microphone in the public service centre contain intimidating phrases and voice samples imitating different officials and sons. The earlier theatre-and-kabaddi performance used constructed voices to reveal deception; here the technique of performance turns voices into instruments of deceit. "Acting" has no automatically virtuous ethical meaning: its purpose and the listener's consent determine its significance. When Kamala recognises a phrase she heard on the telephone written on a page, the aural and documentary worlds appear to corroborate each other. The actual source of the voice, however, remains incompletely identified.

The Newcomer's Right and the Limits Imposed by Privacy

Meera does not demand an immediate public statement from Kamala. She gives her water and listens only to what Kamala chooses to relate. The decision to leave control of the victim's account with the victim echoes the earlier episodes of restoring names. For a moment the scene arrests the movement of the plot, but this pause becomes the narrative's ethical method. By allowing a character to decide whether and how to testify, the writer makes that person not merely a figure within the story but a participant who defines its limits. Nevertheless, the details of the administrative sealing of the room and the preservation of objects remain limited; emotional sensitivity and formal judicial procedure operate at different levels.

"The Real Throat Is Far Away": An Ending of Partial Results

At the end, the public service centre is sealed and Naval's role in providing information is clearer, but the identity of the voice-maker remains to be pursued in the city. When Kamala receives a call from her actual son, the characters recognise a difference in phrasing and rhythm between genuine

affection and manufactured fear. The glowing ears of a ghost near the stump and the river's foam give this incomplete victory a magical image; they do not provide scientific confirmation of a factual claim. "The voice across the river was caught, but the real throat is far away": this duality generates the next chapter. The new river geography has opened the doorway to the city's voices.

Critical Section 269 | Original Chapter 168 — The Throat of the City

"The Throat Belongs to the City, the Names to the Village": The Journey of the Victims' Information

Naresh, a young man from across the river, explains that outsiders took away contact lists on the pretext of scanning old registers. Rather than immediately pursuing the technology used to manufacture voices, the narrative first asks how names travelled. How did information about village elders' debts, pensions, lawsuits, families and migrant relatives reach brokers in the city? This causal question supplies the chapter's structure. By connecting stolen voices to stolen information about relationships, the writer gives telephone fraud a larger institutional context. Village and city are not merely contrasting settings: papers continually travelling between them create the narrative geography that joins the two.

The Noise of the Bus Stand: Auditory Focalisation

After an environment in which a village whisper could be heard, the horns, cries, mobile phones and loudspeakers of the city assail Aruni's ears. The narrator identifies the city not primarily by its visual appearance but through the density of its sounds. Noise becomes a "curtain" behind which the counterfeit throat can hide. The aesthetic force of the device lies in concealment occurring within the very auditory medium that enables the crime. Yet not every urban sound causes or represents wrongdoing. This is the character's experience extended into the plot's symbolism, and recognition of that limit safeguards the story's social plausibility.

From "M. Services" to "Mitra Data Solutions": The Art of Changing Names

At the address written on Naresh's old slip, the group finds a new signboard. A young man says the former establishment has closed, but the familiar lane and room invite questions. The change from one name to another at the same location gives a modern commercial form to the novel's recurring motif of erasing and replacing names. An office's change of name, however, does not by itself prove the uninterrupted operation of a criminal enterprise. The characters develop suspicions by comparing the slip, the people present and the proximity of objects. Because these links remain conditional, the mystery retains its dramatic force without pre-empting a judicial conclusion.

Recorded Speech and a Living Threat: A Mixed Auditory Performance

A deep voice heard from an inner room reminds an elderly client of an earlier telephone call. Devika, drawing upon her experience of acting, hears a difference between rehearsed utterance and the rhythm of a recording. The passage thus multiplies possible sources: not every fragment of a single apparent voice need emerge from the same human body; some portions may be recorded, others spoken live. The narrator makes that mixture a defining feature of the network of voices. The elder's injunction to "recognise the breathing" carries the emotional knowledge of memory, but is not a conclusive specialist analysis of sound. Different capacities for listening enlarge the narrative's plurality of voices.

"C-Group: Rural Elders": A New Body for the Code

The words "C-Group" appear on a box in the city. The recurring English letter connects, in the reader's memory, the archive's "C Section," the office's "C Room," "C-17" at the ghat and the city's "C-Group." Through the return of this code the author establishes a degree of unity among locations scattered across a long novel. The text does not, however, make clear that the letter C follows precisely the same internal naming system everywhere. Criticism must therefore read the repetition as a means of connecting memories, not as sufficient evidence of a single unseen controller behind every occurrence.

The Pause Before Touching the Screen: Narrative Self-Restraint

A young man attempts to shut down the computer, but Aruni refrains from photographing private lists without permission. Meera asks for witnesses and lawful procedure, while Satyavrat informs a local advocate. Although the screen remains open, the desire to gain immediate knowledge is held in check. This restraint is a significant narrative design in the present sequence. Readers are denied the complete names on the screen, but the withholding establishes protection for the victims' private lives. Interrupting the pace of a judicial thriller also becomes a literary method: ethical caution governs what the narrative permits itself to reveal.

Two Registers Merely Seen: Reading Deferred

Beneath a table lie two registers titled "Voice Batch 3" and "Village Story Signals," but the group does not immediately open and read them. Their titles become a promise of future narrative knowledge. The narrator offers readers the expectation of an answer without appropriating the contents of the objects improperly. As the meanings remain unknown, suspense increases. "Village Story Signals" sets the novel's own world of lived village stories against the terminology of criminal lists, as though someone were converting living conversations into secret codes. The registers' untouched

condition is therefore more than an investigative delay; it is a form of literary suspension.

Seizure and Police Reluctance: An Institutional Scene

The city police initially wish to categorise the incident as an ordinary cybercrime. Satyavrat recounts the chain linking Tetri Ghat, the red ledgers, the centre across the river, M. Services and C-Group. This act of recounting turns previously separate incidents into a structurally connected story and presses the listening institution to reconsider its classification. Police arrival and seizure mark the beginning of an actual response, not a final determination of guilt. The text does not describe in full the secure transfer and custody of the documentary evidence. Such compression of institutional procedure requires critical notice even while the narrative gains momentum.

"Chandra 2": An Open Door Instead of a Complete Name

An open computer page reads "Chandra 2: old file active." Chandrapal's full name is absent, but the reader's earlier knowledge immediately summons his shadow. The author uses that inducement of memory to create the chapter's final puzzle: is the code an abbreviated personal name or an independent commercial identifier? The answer remains uncertain. A character's observation that "the throat was found in the city, but only half the body was found" acknowledges the limits of the inquiry. The C-Group papers and the Chandra 2 entry are resources for suspense, not a completed indictment.

The Crocodile: Its Mouth Towards the City, Its Tail in Village Mud

At the chapter's end the crocodile appears in the river with its mouth turned towards the city, its tail lodged in village mud and the middle of its body submerged. This image is the geographical metaphor of the entire sequence: exploitable information originates in the village, counterfeit voices are made in the city and the body of the network stretches between them. The magical image allows readers momentarily to visualise the otherwise indistinct boundary of the crime. The crocodile does not itself provide a physical map of that network; it functions as a symbol within a popular way of seeing. The incomplete urban investigation thus raises another question about names.

The Achievement and Limits of the Transition

Chapter 168 links the theft of information across the river, changed urban business names, rehearsal of counterfeit voices and the police's first seizure into an organised sequence. The author succeeds in carrying a narrative across several locations. Yet government agencies, private offices and

volunteer village watchkeepers reach one another almost immediately; this density of movement occasionally compresses realistic time. From a critical perspective, the almost cinematic succession both strengthens suspense and limits procedural elaboration. The story does not end with the appearance of Chandra 2: it advances towards another site of uncertainty.

Critical Section 270 | Original Chapter 169 — The Door of Chandra Two

A Number Added to a Name: The Division of Identity

The reference to "Chandra 2" was left as a mystery at the end of the preceding chapter. Here, the fragment of a name and the numeral two become the basis for inquiry. The partial identity recalls to readers Chandrapal's earlier political and social prestige, but Meera immediately prevents the code from being treated as a declaration of one person's guilt. The numeral diminishes the directness of naming while also allowing an avenue of defence. At the intersection of an old name's reputation, commercial shorthand and the manufacture of false identities, the novel produces a carefully maintained narrative uncertainty.

Inside the Service Office: The Language of Compassion Turned into Business

Behind the old vegetable market, elderly people crowd the "Chandra Service Office" seeking assistance with pensions, insurance, ration entitlements and paperwork. The signboard advertises ordinary services, but phrases at the counter—"video verification," "quickly," "tell no one"—activate fears born of need. The author does not immediately label this public place a violent den; its everyday routine is shown first. The narrative's anxiety arises from the resemblance between normal administrative procedure and the language of criminal pressure. Without treating the need for pension forms as incriminating, the scene exposes how that need may be exploited.

Categories of Emotional Cues: The Secret Reader Exposed

Files in the office classify which names frighten elderly people, whose sons live elsewhere and whose lawsuits have remained pending. What once belonged to the circle of family feeling has become a commercial column headed "emotional cues." The scene is an urban, written version of the "map of victims" previously drawn on a wall in Chapter 164. Beyond the collection of factual data, the writer reveals violence in the act of reading: someone studies another person solely in order to prepare the sentence that will frighten them. The social significance of names is reversed when remembered relationships become instruments of pressure.

Chandramohan's Premature Reaction: Self-Disclosure in Dialogue

Chandramohan, sitting at the counter, declares that suspicion against him as "Chandra 2" is unjustified, although Meera is said not yet to have

uttered that name. Satyavrat notices the premature response. Mystery narratives often allow a character in haste to answer a question before anyone has asked it; the reader experiences the satisfaction of apparent self-betrayal. Critically, however, this is not automatically a confession of a crime. The chapter does not exclude the possibility that Chandramohan heard the name through some earlier channel. The dramatic effect of the exchange must be distinguished from what can legitimately be concluded about events.

The Phone in the Drawer and "Chandra 1": Another Door

The office phone lists contacts labelled C-Group, Madhukar, Naresh and "Chandra 1." The appearance of Chandra 1 behind Chandra 2 suggests a wider chain rather than an isolated individual. The numbered sequence gives an impression of hierarchical organisation, but does not establish an actual map of criminal authority. Each name places a still-unseen individual or role before the reader's attention. Information itself has become the moving force of the narrative: a word saved in a phone is the seed of the next chapter's title.

"Use the Names of Old Trust": A Foreshadowing of the Paternal Voice

A sheet in the rear room lists forms of address for practice: "Batuk Babu," "Panditji," "Uncle Chandrapal," and "Court Babu." Here a person's name does not prove the person's actual presence; it becomes prepared language for eliciting trust. Calling someone uncle or babu, or invoking an official position, may return a listener to earlier habits of social deference. The writer shows the double life of inherited titles: marks of recognition within a community and material for imitation in a criminal operation. Accordingly, the search for Chandra 1 gradually turns from an apparently identifiable person towards a linguistic mask.

"New Plunder through Old Delay": The Technique of Temporal Interest

The lists of old lawsuits, insecure landholdings and relatives living away from home recall the twenty-three years of waiting in the courthouse veranda. An earlier institutional duration now returns as the immediate menace of a telephone call. The fear accumulated through years of litigation can be mobilised to demand money within five minutes; this compression of time carries the novel's irony. The observation that "the swindler arrives on time" is a moral comparison, not a verdict upon every real court case. The opposed rhythms of delay and urgency also govern the movement of the narrative.

"I Am Not Alone": The Language of Complicity

Under growing suspicion, Chandramohan says that the lists came from "above" and that he only matched the entries. Similar variations on "I only..." appeared earlier in the statements of the clerk, Ramlakhan, Bhikhari Lal and Naval. Through repetition, the novel moves from the portrayal of individual personalities towards a critique of institutional roles. Each intermediary admits to one small portion of the work while avoiding ownership of its consequences. The narrator does not turn this succession into a plea for sympathy; it becomes the substance of the network's construction through many participants.

The Sealed Ledger and a Public Assurance

After examining the old trust list, Meera has the ledger sealed and does not read private names aloud without permission. The office signboard is not removed, but a notice states that the matter is under investigation. The scene holds together the urge to uncover and the obligation not to destroy or expose indiscriminately. Resisting the crowd's immediate desire to name culprits accords with the novel's sequence of public hearings. The details of official sealing and transfer to witnesses remain limited, however; the dramatic pace allows little time for elaborating those procedures.

The Temptation to Unmask the Guilty and Critical Doubt

Chandramohan's untimely words, the Chandra 1 contact, the reference sheets and finally the invocation of orders from "above" open several doors of mystery in a single scene. Readers naturally want to hear the name of an influential figure. The narrative itself cautions that an old name and a new hand need not be the same. Despite that caution, parts of the scene rely on relatively easy admissions. Compared with the time required for rigorous investigation, a character's linguistic weakness exposes the network with unusual speed. Such acceleration heightens the mystery's attraction while raising questions about procedural plausibility within the fictional world.

The Call of "Chandra 1": A Question at the Chapter's Close

The chapter ends with Chandramohan softly uttering "Chandra 1." The writer has opened the door marked Chandra 2, only to place the first door behind it. This is not a metaphor for an endless succession of guards, but a specific causal expectation: first the telephone's throat was located, then a counter serving the network appeared, and now the inquiry must seek the mask of authoritative speech. Chandrapal himself has not entered the scene. What has become clear is only that the prestige of his name might be used as criminal material. The next chapter gives shape to this expectation.

Critical Section 271 | Original Chapter 170 — The Shell of Chandra One

From “Chandra 1” to “Paternal Voice”: The Fragmentation of a Name

At the end of *The Door of Chandra Two*, “Chandra 1” seemed to signify a person or a senior official. In the present chapter, the ledger entry “Chandra 1: paternal voice” changes that expectation. Chandra 1 may not denote a single independent individual but a style of speech designed to inspire trust by invoking fathers, uncles, teachers and government officials. The author supplies another mystery in the guise of an answer: the deception first prompts readers to search for an imagined “real Chandra,” then reveals the voice of remembered social authority. The stable identity of the name breaks down as the question shifts from whom to seek to how a voice was made.

“Families Awaiting Justice”: The Temporal Selection of Targets

The first filtering category in the old trust list is said to comprise families awaiting decisions from the courts. The characters’ old lawsuits constitute the story’s memory; criminals convert that memory into a means of pressure. Readers who have witnessed years of waiting in the court veranda understand why a counterfeit official’s words can immediately frighten such a household. The author links the long duration of injustice to the urgent brevity of a threatening phone call. These two movements of time —slow justice and rapid fraud—give meaning to each other.

Room Seven: The Old Craft of Writing and the New Production of Sound

In the city’s old typing lane, stamp makers, photocopy shops, computers and typewriters appear side by side. Mohanlal Jha’s Room Seven contains instruments for both typing and sound recording. The author turns the technological history of communication into the visible interior of a small room: the craft once used for completing forms now produces the sentences of counterfeit speech. Fraud is consequently not presented as a marvel arising only from new technology; the language of older documents supplies its raw material. The physical setting becomes a moral reinterpretation of the subject matter.

“I Only Write It Down”: The Distance Between Maker and Use

Mohanlal Jha insists that he does not make telephone calls; he merely writes the scripts of fear. His defence echoes Naval’s “only the numbers,” Ramlakhan’s “carrying messages” and the clerk’s claim that orders came

"from above." This recurrence is the author's technique for representing the fragmentation of responsibility across the cast. Each participant wishes to erect a screen between a particular skill and its consequences, although the words written on paper have already injured Kamala's life. Readers are therefore asked to examine the moral distance between creating a text and the uses to which that text is put.

Five Stages of Pressure upon a Mother's Mind: The Crime of Sentence-Making

A sheet found on Mohanlal's desk gives the steps in order: isolate the victim, recall an old case, invoke the son's name, use an authoritative voice and demand money immediately. The author converts a personal catastrophe into a criminal training sequence. At the narratological level, this is an embedded "script" corresponding to the telephone ordeal previously suffered by Kamala Devi. Readers first encountered the pain of the event and only later discover the scheme by which it was constructed. This reversal in the distribution of knowledge makes the earlier scene newly intelligible, without diminishing the reality of the suffering it depicted.

Pen Drives Marked "Father" and "Officer": The Strange Life of Familiar Voices

Two pen drives are found, labelled "Father" and "Officer." Personal names have disappeared from these labels, leaving only categories of relationship and rank. Voices originally associated with reassurance at home are put to work as threats in imitation. Within the story, a paternal voice belongs both to an actual human relationship and to an instrument of disguise used in crime. Collapsing the two would weaken the novel's pathos. The narrative power of the "paternal voice" lies in the misuse of remembered trust, not in a condemnation of fatherhood or of the entire social relationship evoked by the name.

Chandrapal's Old Speech: The Auditory Remnant of Prestige

A red file contains an excerpt of Chandrapal's speech cut from an old public meeting. His name is present as a source of recorded sound, but there is no scene here proving that he personally made fraudulent calls. The possibility emerges that prestige, old habits of deference and collective recognition have allowed a name to become the currency of a counterfeit voice. The writer connects the techniques of current wrongdoing to the public memory of an earlier powerful character. Precisely here, critical interpretation must distinguish direct personal responsibility from the indirect misuse of a person's name and recorded speech.

Ownership of the Voice: Who Has the Right to Be Heard?

Mohanlal's written sheets, recorded samples, fragments of speeches and the intimate rhythm of Kamala's family voice collectively raise the question of authorship over sound. What is written, what is spoken, what is recorded and what a listener experiences belong to different kinds of ownership and relationship. Criminals profit by violating those separations: they manufacture the sound of authority they do not possess and threaten households to which they do not belong under the guise of family ties. The plot has moved from the "seal on paper" to the "seal of the voice." At this point the novel's long documentary sequence becomes a critique of social listening.

The Speed of Mohanlal's Admission: Moral Impact and a Realist Problem

On hearing Kamala's testimony, Mohanlal's resistance crumbles and he names certain intermediaries. The moment has emotional force: the writer makes a character confront what his own carefully made words of fear have done to a victim's life. Yet the speed of the revelation also invites critical inquiry. A long-standing participant in a criminal business may not plausibly disclose extensive information after only one or two exchanges. With limited foreshadowing of an inner change, the dramatic intensity of the admission moves somewhat ahead of realist credibility. The text leaves that tension unresolved rather than furnishing a full explanation.

Two Moons Reflected in Water: The Divided Body of a Name

At the end the crocodile cuts across the moon's reflection, and for a moment two moons seem to appear upon the water. The repeated names "Chandra 1" and "Chandra 2" assume visible form in the river's light. This magical image is no catalogue of evidence: the novel's mythic natural world gives a body to a linguistic division. The moon breaks and joins again, whereas the opening of the criminal network's first circle leaves the larger social night intact. The symbol's incompleteness connects with the "shell" of the chapter's title. Once the outer covering has been removed, the centre remains unnamed.

Closing the First Circle: A Structural Achievement

The chapter's conclusion announces the closure of the first large circle of digital fear. The Chandra 2 office, the composite mask of Chandra 1's authority, Mohanlal's room and Madhukar's shadow have been read as a connected sequence. But "closure" is not a legal ending to the crime; it is the moment at which one interpretive layer of the mystery becomes

accessible. Many identities remain uncertain, much money has not been returned and many families still live with fear. By exposing the technique of the drama of voices, the narrator prepares the next scene of collective listening. This limited narrative pause allows the invisible court to emerge as a fresh beginning.

Critical Section 272 | Original Chapter 171 — The Invisible Court at Channa Grove

A Court Without Walls: From a Place of Performance to a Collective Ear

Following the Videha Theatre Festival, the travelling chaupal and the recitation of dates in the court veranda, an invisible court takes shape beside Channa Grove. Here there is no government seal, no elevated chair or judge's dais. At the outset Meera makes clear that no official verdict will be delivered: fear, memory and experience will instead receive a collective hearing. Thus "court" does not mean an imitation empowered to replace a legal institution; it is a metaphor for a social place in which people can be heard. Avoiding premature claims of complete punishment forms the ethical foundation of this scene.

Three Stones—Name, Fear and Testimony: A Symbolic Institution

At the stump's roots Ananya forms a circle of red thread and places within it three stones named "Name," "Fear" and "Testimony." The written law has its disciplined furniture of desks and files; this circle organises itself through earth, stones, thread and listening. The three objects are more than decoration. A speaker first positions the self, then recognises the limits of fear, and only then gives words to experience. In this sequence the character's embodied life becomes the starting point of the record. Nothing demonstrates that the stones possess magical power; the community treats them as the basis of rules it has chosen to make.

Kamala Devi's Phone: From Private Humiliation to Public Speech

Kamala arrives with her mobile phone wrapped in the end of her sari, as if the instrument were a living embodiment of grief. She explains that she had been ordered to remain silent supposedly to protect her son. This is not merely a retelling of an incident: she changes the meaning of her earlier decision. At first, "tell nobody" appeared to her as a way of safeguarding her family; in a public hearing she recognises it as a method of exploitation. The transformation of a trembling voice constructs a journey of consciousness alongside the reader's sympathy. The narrative does not announce that her money has been recovered.

Lakshman Yadav's Shrinking Field: The Map Against the Body

Lakshman says that the area of his field has grown smaller in official files even as the land-revenue receipts have remained unchanged. The contradiction brings together the altered measurement on paper and the

enduring experience of physical labour on the land. Satyavrat urges that the land dispute be read as a demarcation of the body itself. Earlier cycles of transplanting, stolen seed and flowing water return through the voice of one farmer. When calculations on paper are detached from lived experience of soil, place itself becomes a document contradicting memory.

The Distance of the Migrant Son: The Empty Space Within the Crime

A young migrant says that his genuine calls reached home less often than the swindler's voice. The statement suggests that the crime's success cannot be attributed solely to technical expertise; distance between family members also assumes a narrative role. It would nevertheless diminish the complexity of the scene to blame the migrant son for the fraud merely because he lived away from home. The entry of imitation into an absence of familiar affection supplies the chapter's tragic motif. The authentic rhythm of a voice is formed in the continuing practice of social relations, not simply in the transmission of recognisable sounds.

Shivnarayan Mishra's Counter-Sample: Responsibility for Language

Shivnarayan, an elderly writer of stamped documents, acknowledges having helped prepare model letters intended to frighten people. Meera asks not for an instant punishment but what he will do next. He proposes to draft defensive letters through which people threatened on the phone might find words with which to respond in their own language. A skill formerly supplying the raw material of exploitation may thus become a means of educating resistance. Yet a promise of reparation does not automatically absolve previous harm. The test of the character's subsequent actions remains open; the incompleteness of this dramatic resolution is essential.

Protected Testimony from an Unnamed Woman: The Right to Silence Too

A woman who has endured pressure to sign documents after her husband's death and the accumulation of debt does not wish her name made public. Meera stops the camera and has the entry recorded as "Pressure at the Threshold" instead of a personal name. Here the invisible court reveals its real restraint. A platform that obliges every victim to name themselves risks producing a new form of violence. The victim's consent must govern the making of a public account. This scene internally corrects the earlier campaign to save names: preserving a name and exposing it to everyone are not the same act.

Red, Yellow and Black Threads: Classifying Sight, Hearsay and Fear

Towards evening the testimonies are arranged using three colours of thread: red for what was directly seen, yellow for what was heard from others, and black for fear or conjecture. More yellow than red thread appears on the stump, and black is most abundant of all. This visual device gives the community's proportions of firsthand information, circulating report and insecurity a concrete form. The threads mark different levels of knowledge within the story; they are not official certificates of forensic proof. The need for such distinctions becomes even clearer when the crocodile, viewed through popular fear, assumes the appearance of threatening teeth.

A Circle of Ghosts: Supernatural Presence and Popular Perception

A black ghost seems to attempt to cross the boundary of red thread while a white spirit prevents it. A bird catches yellow thread between patches of black, and the crocodile remains motionless in the water. The narrator does not compel readers to accept the scene as a demonstration of physically verifiable magic. It is a dramatic shadow of collective moral conflict: fear sustained in isolation confronts the courage of common listening. The earlier discipline of distinguishing witnessed marks, symbols and written statements within the register continues here.

Satyavrat Changes Places: From Judge to Listener

Satyavrat initially sits outside the circle, affixing no seal and distributing no papers. Later he enters and treats the community's repeated fears as the beginning of a hearing. This is not merely the easy transformation of a court official into a popular hero: the reader remembers his former silence and belated acceptance of responsibility. Bhikhari Lal ties an old key to red thread and hangs it on the stump; an instrument for opening locks becomes a symbol of listening. In these paired transformations the institutional characters rewrite their roles, but the lawful authority of a court is not transferred to this invisible assembly.

The Final Account: Not a Verdict, but the Grammar of Fear

At night's end Satyavrat writes that the first day of the invisible court delivered no verdict, but exposed the grammar of fear. The sentence prevents a misleading interpretation of the chapter's title. Threads of testimony do not send anyone to prison; lost bank funds do not return by themselves, nor are field measurements immediately corrected. The community identifies the mechanisms of isolation, authoritative speech, urgency and imposed silence. This understanding may become the language of future resistance. Rather than declaring the incident a story of justice fully achieved, the novel makes it the beginning of social listening.

Madhukar's Shadow and the Uncertain Road Ahead

During the hearing there is talk of Madhukar's earlier surveys, panchayat papers and possible links with Chandrapal's people. Meera insists on separating what has been seen from what has been heard and what is merely feared. The chapter approaches its close by resisting a flood of undifferentiated accusations. Although the composite voice-mask called Chandra 1 has been opened, Madhukar's actual role remains uncertain. The three threads at the stump become the visible form of an unfinished network. The invisible court is therefore not a closed result, but an ethical condition for the next inquiry.

Inter-Sectional Discussion: From the Belly of the Shadow to the Invisible Court

The sequence spanning Chapters 164–171 moves fundamentally from the discovery of the network's body towards the unmasking of its voices. "17/C," encountered in the seventeenth cupboard of the record room, leads first to the C Room of Chandrapal's service office, then to a box marked C-17 and the contents of the storehouse at Tetri Ghat. Five red ledgers suggest connections among copied documents, counterfeit deaths, payments and the practice of voices. The public service centre across the river opens a route by which village families' names reach urban brokers; the city recording room and Chandra Service Office disclose a possible process for turning trusted speech into a commodity. Finally, the circle of testimony at Channa Grove returns this movement to a social hearing. Every answer in the mystery opens another source, without becoming a final judgment.

The construction of space is particularly meaningful. The dark record room, Chandrapal's C Room, a ventilator in the rear lane, the C-17 box, Tetri Ghat on the river, the middle of the boat, the cyber shop across the river, the city bus stand, Room Seven in the typing lane and the stump at Channa Grove are not interchangeable sites of action. Each possesses its own rules of listening. Papers speak in the locked cupboard; on the boat a telephone becomes a public loudspeaker; urban noise serves as a curtain for counterfeit speech; at the stump, coloured threads distinguish direct observation, hearsay and fear. This design has a limitation: Chapter 166 is titled "The Storehouse at Imli Ghat," whereas its principal setting is consistently called Tetri Ghat. The original text does not clarify how these names are related, so the criticism identifies an inconsistency in place-naming.

Contrasting speeds of time are another major technique of suspense. At night an empty place is found in cupboard seventeen, and by morning the route of "17/C" opens; the storehouse is not broken into in darkness but inspected in daylight. Meanwhile, families who have waited years for justice are threatened over the phone with demands for an answer "right now." Prolonged judicial suspension and the instant command of fear are opposing temporal forces within the same social network. Three successive money transfers construct one family's loss in stages; five ledgers suggest the possible spread of an institutional network. The author sharpens the

events through these collisions of time, although the detailed sequence of lawful seizures, seals and transfers of digital material is compressed at certain points.

The limits of the characters' knowledge are maintained. Parmanand remembers only part of a telephone instruction; Nageshwar's receipt suggests a link with the office; an elderly boatman recounts the movement of a boat and a box; Naval repeatedly diminishes and modifies his role; Naresh describes the old scanning operation; Chandramohan says the lists came from "above"; and Mohanlal Jha admits writing lines for the voices. Such statements do not necessarily confirm or contradict one another: partial knowledge combines to generate further questions. Meera repeatedly postpones conclusions. Some admissions, however, come extraordinarily soon after the events. The rapid emotional disclosures by several intermediaries within a day quicken the plot at the cost of a degree of realist plausibility; that limitation remains a legitimate subject of criticism.

The return of signs is a distinctive feature of the narrative weave. Number seventeen, C Section, C Room, C-17, C-Group, "Chandra 2" and "Chandra 1" direct readers back towards earlier pages. The signs do not all mean the same thing, but their reappearance creates an expectation of causal comparison. At first "Chandra 1" suggests a senior individual; later it is revealed as a composite mask of authority under the heading "paternal voice." An old public speech, pen drives labelled "Father" and "Officer," and a script for pressuring a mother show that falsehood steals not only personal names but also the rhythm of socially established credibility. A proper reading of this auditory narrative distinguishes the actual owner of a voice, its fabricator, the person speaking and the person listening. Magical images reconnect the sequence with the river's foundational world. Amid questions concerning the C-17 box, the crocodile looks towards the ghat; after the fraudulent phone call, foam rises on the river like breath; at the end of the city inquiry, the crocodile's mouth faces the city and its tail rests in village mud; after "Chandra 1" and "Chandra 2," the moon's reflection divides and rejoins. In the invisible court at Channa Grove, ghosts seem to perform conflicting positions towards the act of listening. These are not forensic descriptions of fact, but poetic bodies for the perceptions of the narrator and the community. Meera keeps signs of popular belief distinct from the evidence register, so the magical narrative is not forcibly installed in the place of the social record.

The final chapter, 171, does not complete the sequence by transforming it into an official court. Instead, a hearing begins around the stones named Name, Fear and Testimony. Kamala Devi changes the meaning of her fear by speaking of it publicly; Lakshman Yadav connects a field's measured boundaries with the limits imposed upon a body; the migrant son reflects upon distance from home; Shivnarayan Mishra promises to convert threatening sample letters into letters of defence; and an unnamed woman gains the right to withhold her name. Red thread signifies direct observation, yellow reported testimony and black fear. These colours acknowledge the limits of a community record. No one has thereby been pronounced automatically innocent or guilty; the banks have not restored every loss, and the land disputes remain unresolved. The story presents the

incomplete but necessary practice of ending individual silence and enlarging collective responsibility, rather than a total judicial triumph. Major questions remain unanswered in this narrative sequence. To what extent can Chandrapal's direct involvement be established? What is the full pattern by which Madhukar handled information? How can the original files, rehearsal sheets and carbon impressions be reliably preserved? And how can the structure of the crime become publicly legible without exposing victims' names? Because these questions remain, the invisible court is not an ending but the ethical beginning of the chapters to come. The significance of the novel's extended narrative lies here: behind every object "opened" another relationship appears, yet the text does not demand belief in a triumph founded on omniscience.

Critical Section 273 | Original Chapter 172 — Reading the Knot

Three Colours: The Visual Grammar of Testimony

In the preceding chapter, fear began to be voiced publicly near Channa Grove; here, a method for interpreting that testimony takes shape. Ananya places knots of red, yellow and black thread in separate baskets. Red corresponds to an event or object directly witnessed; yellow, to a statement heard through another person; and black, to individual or collective fear. Colour is not mere ornament: within the story it becomes a material means of measuring distance from knowledge. Readers, too, begin to understand the limits of each speaker's reliability through this colour scheme. The making of a community archive thereby becomes a counterpart to the novel's own method of narration.

Green in the Song and Black in the Narrative: An Internal Inconsistency of Signs

The opening invocation of the chapter's folk song speaks of red, yellow and green threads, whereas the introductory explanation and principal action of the chapter consistently identify the third colour as black. Green might evoke hope, renewal or a living root; black has become established as a sign of fear and uncertainty. The original text offers no explicit incident in which the two colours are exchanged or one gradually changes into the other. The criticism should therefore not treat this as incontrovertible evidence of a symbolic reversal. It is a colour inconsistency between the song and the narrative arrangement that deserves to be recorded. Despite this instability, the main classification of testimony remains orderly.

Lakshman Yadav's Red Knot: Even Papers Seen Directly Contradict One Another

Lakshman Yadav brings field measurements, an old khasra land record, receipts and pages from a new boundary survey. These are all directly observable objects, yet one page extends the land towards the river, another reduces it towards the road, and a third strikes out letters in a name. In this scene, red signifies not final truth but the beginning of direct examination. The author shows that even documents plainly visible to the eye can quarrel with one another. Aruni and Satyavrat explain why the pages must be laid side by side. The discrepancy between the material history of the land and the words of its documents becomes a new source of narrative tension.

Hospitalisation and Sale on the Same Date: A Conflict of Time

An elderly woman who does not wish her name to be made public finds that the sale of half her house is represented as having been authorised by her thumbprint. She says she was in hospital that day. Devika examines both the hospital slip and the deed of sale: the dates coincide, but the times differ. The narrative presents a visible discrepancy as grounds for investigating possible fraud, not as a verdict of guilt. Protecting the woman's name reinforces a narrative discipline in which the person's dignity is not sacrificed to the pursuit of documentary proof. A ghost's momentary magical intervention makes the suffering visible, but the comparison of dates remains a separate labour of evidence.

The Yellow Knot: Testimony Mediated Through Hearsay

Several villagers speak of Madhukar Babu's earlier survey, his association with Chandrapal's people, and possible signatures in the panchayat box. Meera asks whether someone saw the event personally or heard it from another, when it was heard, and whether the original speaker is still alive. These questions give the yellow knot its form. Questioning a witness is not an insult; it makes the source of the statement clear. Through this recurring pattern of inquiry, what people say ceases to be immediately available as fuel for collective anger and becomes material for an orderly investigation. Many-voiced experience is taking shape not as one uniform truth, but as distinct accounts that can be checked against one another.

Shivnarayan's Letter of Defence: Rewriting the Language of Fear

The seal-writer Shivnarayan Mishra brings both an old specimen letter that once produced fear and a letter of defence that he has drafted himself. The same skill in writing that formerly gave force to the language of fraud now teaches people to recognise isolation, pressure to send money in haste, and a counterfeit police voice. The character's change does not signify that repentance has been completed at once; it marks a change in the direction of his labour as a writer. Kamala Devi proposes an authentic secret signal known within the family. This should be read as a suggestion grounded in familial judgement, not elevated into an infallible technical remedy. Here the narrative turns victims into producers of knowledge.

The Black Knot: The Body of Historical Fear

A young man admits that he has received no telephone call, yet his body trembles at the very word 'police station'. With that admission, black thread ceases to be synonymous with falsehood. It contains a history of institutional humiliation and memories carried across generations. Satyavrat recalls the familiar vocabulary of his veranda—hearing dates, bail and warrants—and realises that the same language may sound

threatening in a poor person's ears. The author connects individual psychology with long social time. Were the criticism to treat fear as evidence equivalent to a directly observed event, this delicate construction would be destroyed. Fear possesses truth at the level of experience.

Phulesar's Question: Breaking the Boundaries of the Prescribed Subject

The child Phulesar asks which colour of knot represents fear about wages and threats concerning education. Between digital fraud and forged land records, this unexpected question opens the limits of the subject the narrative had assigned itself. Devika suggests that both black and red might be applicable. Classification is useful, but an entire human life cannot be fitted easily within it. The child's entrance extends the novel's centre from a criminal network towards ordinary social fears. At this point the red–yellow–black system itself becomes open to question, and that capacity for self-correction is its strength.

Ramkeval's Register: The First Firm Clue in the Narrative Turn

Towards evening, the elderly panchayat worker Ramkeval Paswan brings a register fifteen years old, in which the words 'Madhukar Mishra, Special Survey Assistant' appear. Previously, Madhukar's name had circulated through telephone calls, rooms, rumours and possible memories of a survey; now a written date and an assigned role appear together for the first time. The discovery of the original register does not establish Madhukar's responsibility for every offence, but it gives the formerly scattered accounts a more stable centre. Meera does not immediately turn the register into a stone of public judgement: she asks for a safeguarded copy and a separate account from Ramkeval. That restraint gives the events a credible pace.

The Pace of Untying Knots: An Incomplete Ending

The chapter advances towards the next, 'The Vigil over the Register', through images of the red knot growing heavier, a thread slipping from a bird's beak, and the crocodile's unsettled movement in the water. These images are not a catalogue of facts but a gradual narrative transition. Song, three baskets, exchanges of questions and answers, a hospital slip and the survey register bring many objects into the same chapter; nevertheless, no complete judicial remedy follows. In the author's long narrative method, each day's hearing is not a conclusion but a responsibility carried into the next day. The characters are taught to become patient guardians of truth, not impatient consumers of it.

Critical Section 274 | Original Chapter 173 — The Vigil over the Register

A Leap of Fifteen Years: The Return of Historical Time

Ramkeval's survey register, signed fifteen years earlier, abruptly brings the past into the present network of digital threats. Rather than reenacting the entire former scene, the narrator uses a yellowed page to compel the present to look backwards. The repeated reading of 'Madhukar Mishra, Special Survey Assistant' connects with local memories of the present-day 'Madhukar Babu', but the coincidence of a name does not automatically confirm an entire mode of operation. This temporal arrangement compresses the novel's long span into a single documentary knot and asks readers to undertake the work of comparison.

The Register's Material Existence: From a Cloth Bag to a Communal Stone

Ramkeval brings the register protected inside a cloth bag. Old oil stains, unravelled threads and yellowed inner pages keep the paper from becoming abstract information. Touching it to the earth near Channa Grove and placing it upon a stone is an almost ritual act; Meera, however, immediately turns that ritual into an inventory, copying and a protective watch. The author holds together, on one side, a rural gesture of reverence and, on the other, the work of safeguarding evidence collectively. This conjunction of the object's physical body and its textual history lends credibility to the return of an old name.

'Special Attention': The Ominous Transformation of a Benevolent Administrative Phrase

Beside the names of elderly people, widows, those with relatives living away, litigants and indebted households, the register bears the words 'special attention'. In Ramkeval's recollection, the list was compiled in the name of extending government assistance. Characters involved in the later telephone-fraud investigation see that people in these same categories are being targeted. This transformation in the narrative meaning of words is highly significant: a phrase associated with service becomes a possible marker of prey. The author gives the phrase two opposed meanings within the same sequence of events. Yet whether all subsequent crimes arose from this register remains a question for investigation, not an established allegation.

Public Reading and Privacy: A Double Responsibility

Ramkeval fears that digital photographs may spread into public circulation. Neelmani promises password-protected scans and no sharing on WhatsApp; Aruni proposes a different identifying mark for each copy. The novel does not offer the simple slogan that 'truth must be made public'. Instead, it dramatises the problem of the methods by which truth is disclosed. Protection of the original, the owner's consent and restricted copies become new forms of action within the story. Through this scene, the guardians of names cease to be spectators and become practitioners of archival care.

Dhruvesh's Polite Arrival: The Soft Language of Threat

Dhruvesh, one of Chandrapal's men, arrives neatly dressed and politely proposes depositing the register at the panchayat office. His words appear to favour social peace, but he offers no satisfactory answer when asked about receipts, reasons, permission and inspection. Rather than depicting direct violence, the narrator dramatises the seizure of control over an object beneath a covering of courtesy. Dhruvesh's new role recalls the earlier opposition between the language of service and enforced silence. Nevertheless, readers encounter his ultimate intentions through other characters' perspectives; without lawful inquiry, the full extent of his culpability is not determined.

A Watch in Three Places: Creating Communal Time

After Dhruvesh remarks that the papers should be protected during the night, the narrative organises a nocturnal watch. The plan is to keep the original register in Devika's inner room with Meera and Ramkeval, one copy in Satyavrat's sealed envelope, another on Neelmani's offline computer, and a summary in the children's register. Multiplicity of places becomes a means of security. Formerly, papers disappeared behind the lock of a single office; now several households and different pairs of eyes look after them. This can be understood as an event that moves the document from private possession towards communal responsibility.

The Children's Watch: The Boundary Between Play and Risk

Phulesar and the other children are kept near Devika's courtyard under the pretext of playing, so that the full burden of fear will not be placed on them. This episode opens a tension between entertaining collective courage and the dangers faced by children. The narrator sees their presence as the future of testimony, yet Meera's caution shows that children should not be brought into direct confrontation with criminals during an effort to protect evidence. To read this ethical tension as decorative heroism

would be mistaken. The children's contribution is respected, but the question of adult responsibility remains open.

The Shadow at Midnight: The Difference Between Suspense and Authenticity

The night watch, moving leaves, Devika's inner room and a shadow behind the door create apprehension in the reader. Here the expansive novel joins the atmosphere of mystery to the procedure of investigation. Seeing a shadow does not identify a person, although it makes the possible danger of a document being taken away immediately palpable. The crocodile and ghosts of Channa Grove are not witnesses to facts in this scene; they are poetic embodiments of nocturnal experience. The ethical test is as important as the suspense generated: conjecture must not be entered into the register as truth.

The Politics of Ownership over Names: The Birth of 'Our Right'

When Dhruvesh asks the villagers what right they have to keep the papers, Ananya replies by connecting the bodies, land, thumbprints and years of waiting recorded on those pages. In this exchange, the claim to a right arises not from holding judicial office but from the experience of the human beings represented in the records. This is not a statutory explanation of legal entitlement; it is a declarative moment in the characters' collective self-recognition. The author makes this voice the climax of suspense, yet the immediate outcome of the confrontation is the preservation of the register in several places, not punishment or violence.

Saving the Register: A Narrative of Limited Victory

At the chapter's end, the principal event is the arrangement to protect both the original register and its secure copies. The chronological relationship between Madhukar's earlier survey and present-day fraud is ready to be investigated, but its conclusion remains open. Whether the old survey register was created in the name of 'assistance' or formed part of an offence from the outset must be approached carefully. The author does not turn the moment of obtaining papers into an instant triumph; the document's safety, the owner's trust and the fear of the night stay before the reader. Through this discipline, 'The Vigil over the Register' connects meaningfully with the earlier 'Reading the Knot'.

Critical Section 275 | Original Chapter 174 — The Threshold of the Invisible Court

The Second Architecture of the Invisible Court: The Language of Ten Stones

Near Channa Grove, ten stones are placed in a circle, bearing the names Name, Body, Water, Land, Paper, Fear, Silence, Waiting, Noose and Memory. Rather than the procedural provisions of a formal court, these stones guide a new set of social questions. The narrator converts an open space into an orderly hearing without a government seal or a judge's seat. In this transformation, familiar stones become a symbolic institution. Yet the 'invisible court' does not replace an actual court of law. It is both its echo and its critical counterpart.

Sona: The Body's Rebuttal of the Word 'Absent'

Sona says she appeared in court on every hearing date, yet her file records her as 'not present'. Her sunburnt hands and skin cracked by standing in paddy water confront the words of the file. The author does not convert this opposition into a declaration that she has won her case. Instead, the scene reveals the gap between documentary absence and the body's real journeys. Meera's entry, 'physical presence', changes the category through which the experience is recorded. A word once gained its authority inside an institution; now a woman renames it through her own experience.

Bholaram's Twenty-Three Years: The Time of Files against the Time of Life

The elderly litigant Bholaram measures the years of his lawsuit against his son's education, his daughter-in-law's death, the mortgage of his field and the moment he began walking with a stick. This chronology turns the court's dates into a life narrative. What appeared to the court as mere adjournments became the erosion of generations for a family. Through this scene, the chapter makes visible the human cost of prolonged waiting. The image of a 'judgement written upon the body' is not a legal decision but an experiential metaphor for delay. Within this temporal structure, a brief testimony becomes a concentrated history of the entire family.

'Silent Aunt': The Recurrent Wound of an Incorrect Name

A woman who became silent after her husband's death recounts how her name was entered incorrectly on three documents concerning land, debt and compensation. The story makes the moment when her correct name is spoken a public act of recovery. A minor error in a vowel sign may seem

inconsequential to an administrative office, yet it weakens the links between family property and identity. The chapter does not say whether the papers were corrected or a court order issued. Nevertheless, the collective repetition of the correct name constructs a scene of ethical correction for the reader. This name-centred technique connects widely separated chapters of the novel.

Clerk Ramballabh: Admitting Fear and Entering the Narrative

Ramballabh from the records office lays his private notebook on a stone of the invisible court. He possesses fragmentary information about where missing files were placed and whose orders kept them back. Meera first asks whether she may write down his name; he insists that his fear must be entered too. In this dialogue, someone caught within an opposing system appears not as an enemy in his entirety but as an incomplete witness trapped inside it. His admission is a beginning; verification of the original material remains to be done. Rather than reducing a human being to a list of offences, the narrator situates him between remorse, fear and responsibility.

Staging an Anonymous Objection: Testing the Voice of Rights

An acquaintance of Chandrapal, connected to Hariharan's old household, challenges the legal value of the assembly but falls silent when asked to state his own name. The claim made in public and the refusal to identify the claimant form a dramatic contradiction. Meera restrains the crowd from abuse or violence and has an 'anonymous objection' recorded. By this act of writing, an adversary's voice, too, enters the narrative document. The novel does not build an enclosure in which only supportive statements may be heard: it insists on giving opponents room to speak, even when their argument appears weak.

Magical Listeners: An Assembly of the Living and the Dead

The fleeting appearances of the Old Ghost, the White Spectre and the Black Ghost prevent the gathering at Channa Grove from being merely a physical audience. One figure seems to write upon the air; another pauses beside a stone. The narrator does not establish that every character sees the same vision. The magical realm becomes a metaphor for social memory. The renewed pronunciation of the dead people's names remains tied to Meera's concrete work of recording them in a register; ghosts do not take the place of that activity. Through this layered narration, magical realism and the archival world continue to interrogate one another.

Narrative Self-Repetition: From the Earlier 'Invisible Court' to a New Threshold

Chapter 171 had already described the first day of the 'Invisible Court at Channa Grove', with three stones and three colours of thread. Chapter 174 again constructs a circular assembly, a stone of names, a hearing and a gathering without a verdict, now in greater detail. Ten stones and Ramballabh's notebook enter the new chapter, so its function is also different. Nonetheless, the announcement, collective hearing and conception of a court outside the state return repeatedly. This needs to be read in two ways: as the artistic advantage of a methodical recurrence and as the possible burden of repeating a scene.

The Notebook's First Page: Expanding the Mystery at the Last Moment

At the chapter's end, a night wind opens the first page of Ramballabh's notebook. A clue concerning the actual bearer of Batuknath Hariharan's seal leads the reader towards the next chapter. From within a gathering initially formed to correct the names of victims, the life of a new intermediary figure emerges. This connection is skilful in the management of scenes: the new chapter is not simply another topic but is born from an object belonging to the previous chapter. Yet the mention of a seal-bearer's name alone does not establish criminal intent. The author's concluding mystery preserves precisely that distance.

A Hearing, Not a Punishment: The Ethical Time of the Ending

At the end of the day, Ananya refuses to bind the proceedings to formal expressions such as 'concluded' or 'adjourned', instead describing them as a hearing preserved in community memory. The phrase protests against the state's delays without succumbing to the temptation of declaring oneself an instant judge. Bholaram, Sona and 'Silent Aunt' feel some relief, but their actual cases, land problems and archival difficulties remain unresolved. The narrative distinguishes emotional satisfaction from institutional remedy. That is why the stone marked 'Name' is a guardian of names, not the final seal of a court.

Critical Section 276 | Original Chapter 175 — The Name of the Seal-Bearer

The Entrance of Dinbandhu Jha: A Human Being behind the Object

Ramballabh's notebook contains the words 'Dinbandhu Jha, seal-bearer'. Until now the seal had been a sign of forgery; the life, labour and possible role of the man who carried it now enter the story. Dinbandhu is described neither as an officer nor as a government peon, but as an intermediary who moved among many files. The author brings this overlooked category of work to the centre of the mystery. At the first hearing, one person says he has died and another claims he is living with his daughter. These contradictory accounts expose the incompleteness of community memory.

Shashibhushan's Resistance: The Right to a Father's Memory

When Dinbandhu's son Shashibhushan hears his father's name, he immediately assumes a defensive posture. He fears that the poor seal-bearer will be made the sole culprit for the entire offence. Meera speaks of examining the work behind the name and refuses to turn Shashibhushan's grief into another instrument of accusation. Gradually, the son opens his father's surviving ink pad, brass seal and diary. The decisive change is not an emotional surrender but an acceptance of truth under conditions: any fault attributed to his father must correspond to his actual part, as must the recognition of how his labour was used by others.

The Worn Body of the Seal: The Meaning of Half a Letter

A brass seal with partially worn letters reading 'Hariharan Seva Niketan' turns an object into a narrator once more. Fragments of red sealing wax, the old smell of metal and the cloth around the bundle reveal history's sensory dimension. A possible relationship emerges between the partial impression seen in Ramkeval's register and Dinbandhu's metal seal. Nevertheless, a correspondence of shape suggests a connection between the sources of objects; it does not establish an entire offence. The precision of material description lets readers witness the labour of establishing testimony rather than leap to the simplified conclusion that 'the seal has been found'.

Abbreviations in the Diary: Doors to Several Meanings

Dinbandhu's diary contains signs such as 'red', 'black', 'three copies', 'night', 'B. H.' and 'Ch. Pa.'. The crowd wishes immediately to attach the names Batuknath and Chandrapal to the last two abbreviations, but Ananya stops such guesses. Abbreviations are an especially effective device of mystery because they entice readers with what resembles a half-written

familiar name. At the same time, they test the discipline of interpretation. The author creates the attraction of suspicion, then establishes its limits through Meera's intervention.

Checking Dates against Ramkeval's Register: The Beginning of a Connection

Several dates in Dinbandhu's diary fall close to weeks recorded in the old survey register. A possible sequence begins to appear between pages marked 'special attention' and the note 'three copies'. Readers perceive the structural proximity of objects through this comparison of dates, but the meanings of the written words remain difficult to settle. 'Red' might designate sealing wax, cloth, a mark or something else. If criticism were to invent one meaning and adopt it as certain, the original text's open question would disappear. What matters here is the possibility of a causal connection, not an already demonstrated cause.

Shashibhushan's Voluntary Cooperation: Halting the Inheritance of Guilt

Dhruvesh hints that Shashibhushan should sell the old objects, invoking the fear of dishonouring his father. The son's hesitation is understandable: if the details of his father's life become public, the family's standing may suffer. Meera distinguishes concealing truth from the pain caused by revealing it. Shashibhushan therefore offers the seal for examination, while asking that no false charge be recorded. The novel uses this scene to establish an ethical distance between an individual and a lineage. Questioning one man's role does not automatically make his son guilty by association.

Dhruvesh's Footprint: The Irony of an Evidentiary Image

After Dhruvesh departs, the impression of his shoe is visible in the soil. Sona asks whether this, too, will be entered into the record. Rather than treating it as an exciting accusation, Aruni proposes recording the time of his presence. The visible footprint immediately tempts an interpretation of guilt; noting its time places it only within the sequence of events. This brief exchange condenses the narrative ethics of the whole batch. Not every sign has the same value as proof, and careful attention to context matters more to an archive than the allure of an object.

A Separate Stone for the 'Seal': Institutionalising Trust

Ananya places another stone, marked 'Seal', beside the stone of names. This arrangement indicates that an individual's name and an institution's mark are not the same thing. If counterfeit seals have ruined many people's names, the seal itself becomes visible as an instrument through

which social trust operates. From the search for a worker-intermediary, the chapter arrives at a conceptual distinction. The symbolic placement broadens the meaning of its quiet final image: the question concerns not only personal guilt but also a system that treats a sign as unquestionable authority.

The 'Final List': An Object Creates the Next Stage

At night, a page of Dinbandhu's diary opens to reveal the words 'final list', dated in the week of a service ceremony. This clue becomes the narrative reason for moving an archive of names onto the public stage of that ceremony. The author turns a small page into the key to the next chapter's change of setting. 'Final' is itself an ironic word: just where an inquiry has begun, the list declares itself final. The power concealed in this contradiction prepares the coming chapter's interplay of light and darkness.

Critical Section 277 | Original Chapter 176 — The Darkness of the Service Ceremony

The Double Narrative of Stage and Curtain: The Deception of Light

The scene of a service ceremony held fifteen years earlier re-emerges from the "final list" discovered in the preceding chapter. On the stage are garlands, devotional songs, grain, assistance and the public reading of names; behind the curtain lie the possibilities of making copies, applying seals and exchanging pages. The author confronts the splendour of a social celebration with the concealed techniques of oppression. This contrast does not remain a general observation about social hypocrisy: through papers and photographs it becomes a particular scene reconstructed from material traces. The public recitation and the private archive unfold according to different temporalities, creating a dual narrative within the story.

"Beneficiary," "Special," "Withhold": The Drama of a List's Language

Words found in Dinbandhu's diary—"beneficiary," "applicant," "special," "withhold," "two copies" and "stage"—may seem innocuous when read separately. Read together, they suggest a possible sequence leading to harm suffered by particular people. The author does not assign each word a fixed meaning; its significance remains relative to the events with which it may be connected. Of special importance is the proximity of "stage" to "two copies." Was a second, private version prepared of the names read aloud in public? That becomes the central question for investigation.

Bholaram's Applause: The Alteration of Festive Memory

The elderly Bholaram acknowledges that he, too, applauded along with everyone else at the service ceremony. He now hears the old sound of his palms as a form of regret. The narrative changes the emotional meaning of the past in the light of present inquiry. What had once represented gratitude becomes an uncomfortable recollection of unquestioning trust. Bholaram's act of applauding is not itself a confession of guilt; it is the experience of someone who trusted in the absence of information. Maintaining this distinction allows both compassion for and criticism of the character to survive.

Kamala's Medal and Photographs: Comparing Visual Records

The reconstruction of the ceremony advances with the discovery of a counterfeit medal, a red-bordered certificate and two old photographs. In the photographs Batuknath wears a garland; a queue of people, a makeshift table, a box of seals and a possible bundle of the "final list" are visible. Neelmani preserves the images without enhancing their brightness. The photographs thus become materials for objective examination rather than sentimental memorials. Yet the identification of blurred lettering is not wholly certain: the angle of light and the deterioration of the old images remain fundamental limits upon interpretation.

Ramballabh's Memory of Exchanged Pages: The Importance of Chronology

The clerk Ramballabh remembers that an additional page was attached at the temporary table after a thumb impression had been taken. Hearing Chandrapal's and Dinbandhu's names, Meera stops the crowd from drawing an immediate conclusion. The author makes this memory a reason to compare objects: the date of the ceremony, photographs, the cloth and surviving diary entries. An oral recollection, without external corroboration, is not conclusive evidence. Nonetheless, the alleged difference between the moment of public reading and the later exchange of pages makes the potential manipulation of narrative time the focus of the inquiry.

Wax Marks on the Cloth: An Object Becomes the Skin of the Stage

Bhikhari Lal says he recognises the dingy red-bordered cloth from the service ceremony in an old sack in the records room. Once recovered, it bears round spots of wax, black ink and impressions of fingers. The author gives this voiceless object a narrative role, as though it were the "skin of the stage." The possibility of paper substitution, concealed by the brightness of the ceremony, finds a material surface on which to persist.

No complete chemical or formal comparison of the marks is supplied in the text, however. The recovered cloth is a powerful link in narrative memory, not a final forensic determination.

The Separate Women's Queue: The Gap Between Assistance and Consent

Bholaram's wife Shanti says the women stood in a separate queue under the name of a "women's assistance scheme." Names were read, photographs taken and thumb impressions collected, but the documents were not subsequently delivered to their homes. The narrative makes this separation in physical space an image of gender inequality. The announcement heard by the women, the bodily act of affixing a thumbprint and the later language of the records are not identical experiences. Within the apparently simple statement that someone "gave a thumb impression," the author reveals the absence of understanding and the failure to provide copies. Shanti becomes an authority over her own memory, not merely a representative victim in the crowd.

The Note Saying "Replace the Original": The Limits of a Dramatic Climax

From the bottom of Dinbandhu's seal-box, Shashibhushan retrieves a small note bearing the instruction "Replace the original after the stage reading." The sentence makes the possible purpose of the deception unusually clear. Yet the meaning of the initials "B. H.," the identity of the person who wrote the instruction and the complete chain of implementation have not been established. For this reason, Satyavrat does not immediately level a final accusation against a named person. The chapter derives much of its suspense from that short instruction. Criticism may recognise its dramatic force while keeping the uncertain source of the order unresolved.

Towards a House-to-House Comparison: An Ending of Method, Not Event

The chapter pauses with instructions to compare the ceremony's names, Dinbandhu's list, entries marked for special attention in the register, memories of the women's queue, photographs and the wax-stained cloth. A festival said to have concluded in a single day will have its social effects reread in each household many years later. Structurally, this is a movement from the theatrical stage to domestic thresholds. The truth behind the stage's public brilliance must be tested against the private documents kept in homes. Thus the chapter is not simply a conventional flashback; it is a many-versioned rereading of the past through different objects and witnesses.

The Ceremony's Inconsistent Timing: The Distance Between Memory and Judgment

Photographs, the diary and present-day collective memory all point towards a ceremony some fifteen years earlier, but several characters do not recall it in identical ways. Names read aloud on the stage and the dates on subsequent documents are different kinds of evidence; a shared date or proximity within a week does not establish an entire sequence of acts. Through the dramatic convergence of these materials, the author strengthens the thread of the mystery without delivering a formal verdict on the events. Criticism must maintain that fine distance. Otherwise its reading of the novel would fall into the very haste against which Meera warns throughout this portion of the work.

Critical Section 278 | Original Chapter 177 — Papers from House to House

A House-to-House Journey: From Stage to Threshold

After the public spectacle of the ceremony, the narrative sends teams to separate households. On the stage, names were recited collectively; within each home, the family's papers, bundles, boxes, photographs and grief call for a different account. This movement is an important technique of the long novel: one collective mystery breaks into domestic points of view. Meera's instruction that the originals must remain with their owners, while copies may be made for investigation only with permission, offers the narrator an ethical way of reading individual stories without appropriating them.

Shanti's Yellow Paper: "They Called It Assistance, but Wrote Consent"

At Bholaram's house, Shanti produces an old certificate and a paper marked "voluntary consent." What she remembers hearing from the stage, however, was an announcement of "assistance for vulnerable families." The divergence between two languages applied on the same day provides the first point of comparison. The trembling of Shanti's hand and Meera's decision to read the words aloud before proceeding give the narrative a distinctive moment of pacing. The author makes the authority of the written sentence answerable to the affected woman's audible memory. The complete history of the original document's authenticity or renewal nevertheless remains to be established.

Subhadra's Papers: The Shadow of an Absent Migrant Son

The elderly Subhadra Jha has weak eyesight, and her son lives away from home. After the ceremony, her papers were left with the committee. The document that remains in the house contains the language of a mortgage and Dinbandhu's seal. Her absent son becomes an element in the family's documentary insecurity. The author connects the distance separating rural family members with both older arrangements of pledging property and newer telephone networks. The intermediary's casual reassurance that "the work has been done" can conceal the possibility that citizens have lost control of their own documents. That ambiguity is central to the narrative tension.

Chamru's Four Names: The Archival Fragmentation of One Body

At the ceremony, Chamru Mahato is "Chamru"; on the medal he becomes "Chandu"; in the register he is "Chandramohan"; and in the mortgage deed he appears as "Chamru alias Chandramohan." Presenting four names for one person makes the novel's politics of naming visible. Chamru insists that his body remains one, even though the papers have divided him into four pieces. The scene exposes the complex administrative effects of multiple names. Yet one cannot conclude that all four entries were necessarily created through fraud without examining the source of each document.

Three Teams and Seven Houses: Balancing the Collective and the Particular

By midday, three teams have reached seven houses. Assistance has turned into a donation, a scholarship into relinquishment of rights, and treatment into consent to a loan: a similar process takes different forms from household to household. The enumerative description quickens the narrative pace, although it risks reducing the space allotted to individual women's memories. After fuller scenes involving Shanti, Subhadra and Chamru, the author gives the seven houses a more general treatment. The advantage of this rhythm is that it reveals the spread of an alleged fraudulent method; its limitation is that the families do not all receive equal narrative depth.

Ragini Devi: Two Accounts of Her Husband's Guilt and Fear

Ragini Devi, Dinbandhu's widow, concedes that it would be wrong to declare her husband wholly innocent on the ground that he understood nothing. She has found a torn page instructing that papers be collected from houses and the originals kept "above"; the signature at the bottom is incomplete. Ragini tells her son Shashibhushan to record as much of his father's wrongdoing as can be established—neither less nor more. The narrative refuses to reduce her to the one-dimensional figure of a wrongdoer's wife. She becomes a careful custodian of memory. The incomplete "Chan…" is not in itself a full name; preserving that openness is a responsibility of criticism.

Lalit's Torn Poster: Public Custodianship as Private Possession

Lalit, a former volunteer, first shuts the door of his house, then shows the visitors a torn poster from the service ceremony. Its statement that "the entire archive will remain safely with the organising committee" was presented as a declaration of public welfare, yet may have enabled the collection and retention of original household documents. Lalit recalls an

instruction attributed to Chandrapal. Despite being a small object, the poster reveals the language through which the trust of an entire community could be taken over. The narrative identifies not a proven governmental order but a sentence used as a social pretext, whose source remains uncertain.

The Empty Space in the Centre: Structuring the Absent Person

Near Channa Grove, the day's papers, medals, bundles and testimony are placed in a circle; Ananya leaves the centre empty. Chamru is subsequently seated there, with his four names arranged around him. Through this deliberate vacancy, the author turns an empty space into an object that restores the "human being" missing from the archive. The scene is composed like theatrical stage blocking, but its meaning is created not by acting, but by the presence of the person affected. The earlier symbols of stone and cloth are redefined in the presence of the social body.

Foreshadowing the "Upper Room": An Upward Movement in Space

Ramballabh suggests that original papers taken from households may have been stored in the upper room of the old courthouse, whose key was held by Chandrapal's associates. The house-to-house journey has extended horizontally across the village; the next chapter turns upwards. This spatial arrangement is not accidental. Objects scattered among domestic thresholds may converge in a locked archive above. Nevertheless, the clerk's statement cannot stand in place of the search itself. What the room contains remains the event to be disclosed in the next chapter.

The Limits of the Conclusion: Returning Originals to Their Owners

At the end of the day, the documents collected or examined in the households are returned to their owners, while only permitted copies and descriptions are retained. This practice constitutes the chapter's human conclusion, not a legal judgment. On one side stands Meera's collective list; on the other, the paper placed back in Shanti's trembling hand. The author makes the credibility of the campaign for justice depend upon respect for those who own the documents. The suspenseful prospect of the "upper room" does not erase that balance. The question of whom the papers are being used for must accompany the search into the next location.

Critical Section 279 | Original Chapter 178 — The Upper Room

An Ascent: From the Waiting Veranda to the Locked Store

Climbing the stairs of the old courthouse means more than entering another room. It is a journey from the public delays of the open veranda below towards a possible explanation concealed in the darkness above. The upper room's key is missing from the ring on Bhikhari Lal's waist. The keys that habitually jangled there represented the ordinary routine of administration; the absent key becomes a sign of restricted, concealed access. Through this vertical arrangement of space, the novel exposes layers of authority and control over information.

Lock and Five Witnesses: The Dramatic Limits of a Search

Before breaking open the locked door, the team assembles witnesses, including a court employee and representatives of village women and children; the time of each blow is recorded. Dust, cobwebs and rust respond to every strike as though the sequence were being enacted on a stage. This vivid progression communicates the excitement of the opening, but Meera insists that opening the room is different from looting it. A significant qualification remains: the presence of witnesses alone does not establish full legal authority to break the lock of a government room. The moral and formally legal levels of procedure within the story must be kept distinct.

A Door with Three Seals: The Proximity of Official and Private Signs

Old marks associated with the court, the tehsil and a private service committee are visible together on the door. Why should the private committee's seal stand beside official emblems? This material proximity becomes an image of institutional boundaries being erased. Bhikhari Lal recalls that the committee had gained entry under the name of "assistance." The author generates suspicion through the arrangement of signs, without directly pronouncing collusion to have been proved. In this way a visible object obliges the reader to ask an administrative question.

"Original Copy": A Contradiction in Terms

Labels such as "Ceremony Records" and "Original Copy" are found on the shelves inside. Ananya asks how something can be both original and copy. This small linguistic contradiction contains the possible grammar of the wider fraud. Making an original into a copy, or a copy into an original, becomes a figure for the control of social memory. An unusual combination of words, however, is not itself proof of an offence. Its

significance grows when the next box reveals actual differences between sheets. The narrative moves from a displacement of language to a displacement of objects.

A "Transfer of Rights" Attached on Different Paper

In the first box, an application bearing the seal of Seva Niketan has been supplemented with a transfer-of-rights page made of different paper and written in different ink. The matching thumb impression and the changed sheet generate one of the narrative's strongest material tensions. The author separates the body of the person who supplied the impression from the interpretation added afterwards. What is consent to assistance in one place becomes relinquishment of property in another. The discovery offers new material for the earlier suspicion of deception behind the brightness of the stage. Whose order governed which document, however, remains a question for further investigation.

Photograph Numbers and the Triangle of Testimony

In one photograph of the ceremony, Kamala Devi holds a page marked "approval of assistance"; the associated file speaks instead of "relinquishment of rights." Sona, Neelmani and Ananya record the photograph number, file number and household testimony in separate sequences. Through this three-way comparison, the novel turns a photograph from an emotional keepsake into an active instrument of textual examination. The image shows an object at one moment; the file records another stage of writing; and the family's voice adds a third level of meaning. Criticism must not assume in advance that the three will always agree.

A Separate Bundle of Women's Applications: Violence Through Classification

A bundle tied with red thread contains women's applications filed separately under descriptions such as "widow," "husband absent," "son away from home" and "illiterate." A perpetrator might describe these as categories of convenience; the narrative exposes how they correspond to isolation, lack of information and vulnerability to exploitation. Meera asks who supplied the explanation, and in which language, when she encounters a page marked "explained to the applicant." That question brings the appropriation of archival voice to the centre. A Maithili-speaking woman's account has become a rigid administrative sentence. This is not merely linguistic translation, but a transfer of narrative authority.

The Code Register: A Name Reduced to One Letter

A register of specially secured records contains codes such as K-1, U-1, V-3 and the Ch-group. An accompanying slip connects these with Kamala, Ujjwala, the widows' group and Chamru's category. The full names of individuals shrink into letters that make administrative calculations easier. For the author, these codes are not simply instruments of mystery: they criticise a classification system that distances itself from persons. Earlier, the register had called for "special attention"; now, in the upper room, the person has been reduced to an abbreviated sign. The recurrence deepens the social meaning of the narrative.

Three Seals and Blank Rubber: Instruments of Changing Authority

The room contains a Seva Niketan seal, a tehsil-like mark that appears counterfeit, and a blank piece of rubber for altering names. Declared service, imitation of official authority and the instability of personal names thus become materially present in three objects. The scene is symbolically forceful, but without formal examination of the objects, the relationship between each impression and the authentic governmental records remains inferential. The lists prepared by the children are a way of respecting this evidentiary limit. The discovery also supplies the immediate cause of the next chapter, "The Footprints of the Seal."

Dust, Window and Light: A Magical Scene Opens a New Administrative Route

When the room's window is opened, the easterly wind lifts a curtain of dust; the white ghosts appear to read an impression saying "Send upwards." The magical event figures names that have been suppressed within the story; it is not an independently proven source of documentary information. Afterwards, the characters identify the next route through the tehsil, bank and municipal registration office. Darkness is not exhausted in one room; it extends along the roads connecting institutions. The conclusion of a visually mysterious episode therefore becomes the beginning of another causally motivated journey.

Critical Section 280 | Original Chapter 179 — The Footprints of the Seal

The Seal's Journey: A Sequence of Three Institutions

The Seva Niketan seal, the tehsil-like counterfeit impression and the blank rubber found in the "upper room" carry the story in this chapter into the records of the tehsil, registration office and bank. The author makes the seal's footprints not one continuous physical line, but a sequence of comparisons among separate entries. Connections between names, dates, photographs, loans and accounts reveal why the alleged offence cannot be reduced to deception in a single file. Matching dates and the movement of money, however, do not amount to a final decision about responsibility. The investigative tenor of the narrative is maintained.

The Tehsil Veranda: Another Site of Endless Waiting

The courthouse veranda has symbolised waiting through many preceding chapters. On the tehsil veranda, the invisible sign "Come back later," damp files and exhausted bodies recur. Through a change of location, the author reveals the continuity of suffering imposed by institutional time. Bhikhari Lal once entered places like this as a court attendant; he now enters as a witness. That small alteration in his position gives the same doorway another perspective. Although the guardians of names arrive together, only a limited group proceeds inside, preserving the discipline established in earlier investigations.

One Day, Two Stories for Kamala: From Announcement to Register

In the tehsil land-transfer register, Kamala Devi's name is entered under "voluntary relinquishment of rights"; the ceremony photograph shows approval of assistance on the same date. Through this repeated date, the narrator establishes two parallel stories, public and private, within a single day. The affected woman states what she understood, while the register supplies a different meaning. Meera's question—"Where is the voice in the register?"—lies at the centre of this conflict of language. A receipt acknowledging the application for a certified tehsil copy turns the scene's emotional indignation into a procedure that can be followed up.

An Empty Signature and the Ch-Group: Accounting for Absent Persons

Ujjwala's family entry carries the words "special verification," but the signature space is empty; Chamru's several names have been condensed into the code "Ch-group." The first instance depicts the absence of an

official's accountable signature, the second the disappearance of a person's full name. The author places two forms of absence in the same register: the vacant place where an official might have signed, and the place from which a poor person's name has been erased. This contrast reveals the unequal presence of power and its victims within the record. Why the signature was left blank remains open; criticism must not supply an invented reason.

The Registration Photograph: The Difference Between Image and Consent

In the city registration office, a photograph shows an affected woman with her face partly bowed and a hand pressing her shoulder from one side. Meera reads this bodily arrangement as a sign of pressure. The interpretation is serious, but a photograph fixes a single moment: it cannot, on its own, establish every circumstance in which consent was given or withheld. The story compares its visual language with other documents, statements from the household and dates recorded by the hospital. At this point, criticism must preserve the distance between the photograph's ethical emotional force and a formally established factual finding.

One Body, Two Places: Dates of Hospitalisation and Transfer

One record dates the authorisation of a transfer to the same day on which Shanti was admitted to hospital. Devika asks how one body could have been present in two places on that date. This temporal contradiction sharpens the possibility of fabricated consent or erroneous record keeping. Yet the shared date must be supplemented by examination of times and further verification of identity. The narrative accordingly describes the labour of applying for evidence and collecting copies. Readers encounter the urgency generated by the apparent contradiction, but are not licensed to leap straight to a verdict.

The Bank's Three Streams: Following the Money

After the land transfer come entries relating to a loan, outstanding dues and transfers between bank accounts. The characters read details of funds moving in three directions: to Seva Niketan, to a construction-material supplier, and to the Harihar Kalyan Trust. Batuknath is not named directly, although the service institution has associations close to him. The literary significance of these lines is that the shadow of powerful interests is sought not only in seals, but also in the movement of money. Without examination of sources, to turn the name on an account into a final verdict of guilt would be a critical error.

"Some Sold Trust": A Sentence About an Invisible Economy

An elderly tehsil clerk remembers that some officials read the pages, some trusted them, and some sold trust itself. This threefold statement places three distinct moral conditions of institutional work in a single sentence. The novel makes it a suggestive formulation: trust is a form of capital in human relationships, but, without scrutiny, it may be traded. The old clerk's words nevertheless remain a personal recollection, not proof of identical guilt on the part of every employee. Through the force of this character's sentence, the author invites readers to question the institution.

The Seal's Journey in Light: Map and Lamps

At dusk near Channa Grove, lines are drawn from the service ceremony to the tehsil, registration office, bank and trust account; a small lamp is set at every turn. A catalogue of objects becomes a visible map. White spirits, black ghosts and children sit among the others, giving the ethical movement of the inquiry a poetic shape through magical realism. The lines map a possible structure, not an official determination of guilt. The story's troubling tension lies in the possibility that the footprints of an institution proclaiming service may lead to the victims' money and land.

The Transition Across Eight Chapters: From Knots to Footprints

In Chapter 172, the three colours of knots were read with caution; in 173, the survey register was secured; in 174, the invisible court formed a new circle for hearing testimony; in 175, the seal of Dinbandhu brought a labouring intermediary's name into view; in 176, the possibility of documents being changed behind the brightly lit service ceremony emerged; in 177, papers were compared house by house; in 178, objects from the upper room were collectively inventoried; and in 179, the seal's footprints were traced through the tehsil, registration office and bank. This is not a simple story of "truth discovered," but a sequential narrative connecting sources, copies, memory, institutions and victims' ownership of their own records.

Inter-sectional Discussion: From the Knots to the Footprints of the Seal

The narrative of Chapters 172–179 begins with three coloured knots and comes to rest at the institutional footprints of a seal. The first important feature of this sequence is that the distinction between what has been witnessed directly, what has been heard from others and what is carried within as fear becomes the visual grammar of a people's archive. Meera's restraint, Ananya's classifications, Aruni's questions, Devika's interpretations, Ramkeval's old register, Dinbandhu's seal and the bundles kept by village families are all different vehicles of knowledge. The author does not immediately absorb these vehicles into a single omniscient truth. The inquiry advances from oral testimony to a written register, from the register to seals, from seals to photographs of a ceremony, and from these to the tehsil, registration office and bank. This movement generates both density of events and causal connections in the long novel.

The organisation of narrative space is now particularly legible. The stump in Channa Grove remains the central site of public hearing; Ramkeval's house and Devika's room are places in which records can be kept safe; the stage of the service ceremony is the place of public announcement; individual homes are centres of private memory; the upper room of the courthouse stores suppressed papers; the tehsil and registration office are sites where language acquires an official meaning; and the bank makes the circulation of money traceable. Papers, photographs, thread, stones, cloth, seals and receipts move between these locations. The journey between places empowers the characters, but the kind of evidence changes at every stop. What is heard as a statement at Channa Grove does not necessarily appear in the same form in the tehsil's entry. The author makes that difference itself a force driving the narrative forward.

Time opens at three levels. The survey and service ceremony of fifteen years ago form the centre of the past; present-day hearings at Channa Grove, journeys from house to house and the search of the upper room belong to the advancing time of the plot; and a lawsuit extending over twenty-three years, ageing bodies and losses carried by successive generations constitute a prolonged time of experience. The author sets the date on an old page against the present predicament of a family. For that reason, "one day, two stories" signifies not merely a difference of wording, but a historical division: public assistance and the possible private transfer of rights occurring contemporaneously. Yet events do not become identical merely because their dates match. Photographs, signatures, testimony and written material require additional comparison. This caution is a fundamental value of the novel's own narrative method.

Changes in the presentation of character are equally clear. Ramkeval Paswan safeguards local history by keeping a fifteen-year-old register alive. Shivnarayan Mishra attempts to counter the frightening lines he once wrote by composing a letter of defence. The clerk Ramballabh presents his notebook despite his fear. Shashibhushan, Dinbandhu Jha's son, is caught between the prospect of dishonouring his father and the wish to discover the truth; the widow Ragini Devi resists the desire to erase her husband's responsibility altogether. Shanti, Subhadra, Sona, the "Silent Aunt" and Chamru Mahato call the fixed meanings of records into question through their own experiences. Because of them, the author presents injustice not simply as a conspiracy of hostile men, but as a crisis differently lived by numerous families.

The recurring signs constitute both the beauty and a limitation of this portion of the work. Red, yellow and black thread, the stone bearing names, the locked box, the worn seal, the incomplete signature, the red-bordered cloth, the cut page and the large map of the seal's movements all keep earlier events alive in memory. Yet the opening song of Chapter 172 mentions red, yellow and green, whereas the main narrative employs red, yellow and black; the author supplies no separate event transforming green into black. The invisible court's assembly also returns in Chapters 171 and 174 in somewhat similar arrangements. Such repetition may serve the purpose of communal rehearsal, but it raises an editorial question about recurring scenes. Criticism must register the actual textual differences alongside their possible meanings.

The magical-realist layer returns through the stump at Channa Grove, stones, birds, crocodiles, and black and white ghosts. These supernatural presences cannot be read as equivalent to a signature authenticated upon a document. They are moments that give visual force to the moral intensity of collective experience. At times the ghosts appear to bend over a stain, at times to pause beside a paper, and at others to listen while the living correct their names. This imaginative layer prevents prolonged descriptions of archival labour from becoming inert. Readers must nevertheless maintain the distinctions between kinds of meaning. In several places the original narrative itself enjoins the characters to write down separately what people have seen, what they have heard and what they believe.

The decisive change across these sections is the distinction between "protecting" truth and "using" it. Returning original documents to their owners, retaining digital copies under controlled access, refusing to share photographs without consent, not guessing a name from Ragini Devi's incomplete page, requesting certified copies from government offices, and making the financial trail through the bank an institutional question

rather than an occasion for public humiliation: together, these actions form the narrative's ethical architecture. At the same time, the scene in which witnesses are present as the lock of a closed government room is broken does not fully explain the formal process of legal authorisation. The narrative makes its moral authority a dramatic climax; the criticism does not therefore call it automatically sufficient proof of lawful procedure under contemporary law.

At the end of Chapter 179, the outline of a possible financial flow between the tehsil, registration office, bank and trust emerges on the stone beside a row of lamps. The story has not concluded by establishing Chandrapal's or any other person's guilt in a court of law. Where did an approval of household assistance turn into relinquishment of rights? Where was a counterfeit seal applied? Who ordered an original to be exchanged, and who received a share of the proceeds? How will real control over the victims' names be restored? These questions remain open. In that incompleteness, the long narrative retains its energy. Reading knots, protecting registers, opening the history of seals and tracing money are not images of judicial victory, but stages in a society's difficult reconstruction of itself on the way towards justice.

Critical Section 281 | Original Chapter 180 — The City's Accounts

Entering the City's Accounts: From a Map to a Financial Sequence

In Original Chapter 179, the footprints of the seal had reached the revenue office, the registration office and the bank. Chapter 180 turns that spatial map into a movement of money. The lines drawn on a stone in Channa Grove are brought to the desk of Siddhi Consultancy Services in the city. The purpose of the narration is not to introduce an entirely separate crime, but to interpret the social consequences of the land transfers already encountered. The urban setting does not stand apart as a world unrelated to the village: it becomes the financial translation of the village's dispossessed fields, trust and rights. This continuity gives a long novel a tangible momentum of successive investigation.

The Glass Office versus the Earth on the Footprints

The gleaming railings, glass doors, cool air and fragrant interior of Siddhi Consultancy Services are set against the field soil clinging to the edge of Shanti's shawl. The narrator is doing more than decorating a rich-poor contrast; two different languages of record-keeping are brought together in one visual field. In the accounts, land has become an "amount," whereas in Shanti's memory the date associated with that field remains a loss

within her life. The cleanliness of the office does not guarantee moral purity. The absence of visible dust creates a narrative irony in which concealed financial stains may remain inside.

Govardhan Sahay and the Grammar of "Only"

The accountant Govardhan Sahay attempts to limit his part in the events to "only" arranging papers. The recurrent word "only" becomes a defensive turn of phrase. Ananya recognises this language; by now the reader also understands how the division of wrongdoing and responsibility can be hidden inside apparently minor verbs of action. Govardhan's fear, his production of an envelope and his plea that his name not be made public prevent him from becoming a one-dimensional villain. His admission opens a path for investigation, but it does not demonstrate complete innocence.

The White Purpose of Charity and the Dark Route of Money

The statement of purpose of the Harihar Welfare Trust contains luminous expressions such as widows' rehabilitation, scholarships and disaster relief. Yet the following pages suggest that money arising from land transfers reaches charitable donations by circuitous routes through construction-material suppliers, residential institutions and unnamed accounts. The narrative brings administrative vocabulary into collision with actual transactions. Devika's conclusion—that donations were being made in the names of the very people from whom something had been taken—is more than a moral aphorism. It is a narrative reversal in which the alleged benefactor becomes a possible beneficiary of dispossession. Real investigation moves beyond a document's declared purpose to the way it operates.

"Ra. Cha. La.": The Productive Uncertainty of an Empty Abbreviation

Three letters, "रा.चं.ल." (Ra. Cha. La.), appear against the expenditure item for special administrative cooperation. Aruni considers Raghav, Chandrapal and Lau as possible names, but Meera keeps speculation separate from the register of proof. That brief restraint defines the investigation's ethics. In a conventional mystery, the discovery of a clue can become an instant declaration of guilt; here the clue prolongs the reader's waiting. The narrator withholds the artificial satisfaction of a final answer because the distance between an abbreviation entered in an account and the actual person to whom it might refer remains unresolved.

Shanti's Shawl: The Reversal of Object-Memory

Shanti carries the old shawl received at the ceremony into the city. Once a sign of a charity event, it now asserts its presence beside the investigative

desk. In the folk song, the shawl is transformed from a covering for silence into a place upon which a people's assembly can sit. The prose gives material form to that change through Shanti's hands and the soil on the cloth. An object's meaning is rewritten by the experience of the person who possesses it. In this process, a domestic object associated with a woman gives bodily presence and moral warmth to the abstract figures in a ledger.

The Photograph on Ananya's Phone: From Documents to Digital Threat

A number found in the accountant's envelope and a threatening message accompanied by a photograph of Ananya outside a city bank create the next line of events. The temporal arrangement is significant: surveillance responds while the investigation into the accounts is still in progress. Wrongdoing is not merely an inert history; it is a present force watching its own examination. Devika turns the image on the phone from a source of fear into potential evidence; the time, number, image and words are recorded. At this point, the pace turns from archival inquiry towards immediate danger without becoming an uncontrolled scene of violence.

The Cyber Branch's Familiar Weariness: The Return of an Institutional Setting

The cyber branch displays modern warnings such as “Do not disclose your OTP,” yet the weary expression of the staff recalls the corridors of the revenue office and the court. This change of setting is not merely a demonstration of new technology. The narrator shows that a new office can reproduce an old language of indifference when an official tries to dismiss a threat as something ordinary. Ananya's question breaks through that supposed normality. An institution is defined not by the novelty of its equipment, but by its capacity to hear the particular circumstances of an affected person.

The Metaphor of the Digital Crocodile: An Old Creature's New Hunger

The river crocodile was first a creature that could injure the body; it then became an image of documents devouring land; now it acquires a digital form that consumes reputation, faces and voices from within a phone. The narrative never states as a factual claim that an actual crocodile committed a digital offence. This is a sustained figure of social predation. Traces of times, devices and numbers can also be read figuratively as crocodile footprints. The metaphor's achievement lies in placing folk memory and technological fraud within the same horizon of literary experience while keeping facts and symbols in different categories.

Privacy and Visibility: A Critical Tension

Meera examines the trust's public accounts but refuses to turn victims' thumbprints, faces and private suffering into a public spectacle. This double decision holds one of the narrative's central tensions: truth must circulate socially, but its disclosure must not humiliate those already harmed. Govardhan's fear, Ananya's photograph and Shanti's shawl touch this boundary in different ways. Privacy is not represented as an obstruction to investigation; it is an ethical condition of investigation. Accordingly, the narrative does not open every piece of information to the reader without restraint.

The Accounts' Incomplete Conclusion: A Path to the Next Chapter

The chapter offers no final determination of the trust's complete money trail, the meaning of "रा.चं.ल." or the identity of the person issuing the threats. An office, a number, a message and a chain of older land transfers remain. Such incompleteness is not unnecessary padding to lengthen the events; it is the craft of sequential investigation. The line of inquiry running through the accounts leaves a new question for "The Shadow of the SIM": how did names written on paper come to operate inside a telephone? When one chapter's object becomes the opening sign of the next, the length of an expansive novel acquires continuity through memory.

Critical Section 282 | Original Chapter 181 — The Shadow of the SIM

The Telephone Number: A Stable Method behind Changing Identities

After the city's accounts, the narrative follows the journey of a mobile number found among the records. Information from the cyber branch indicates that its registered name and address changed seven times within three months, although a trace of its original connection with the bus stand survives. Here a number is not a person but a changing route towards a person. The narrator does not make the technical properties of a mobile phone the complete explanation of wrongdoing; instead, it examines how the same method persists beneath successive identities. The SIM's shadow becomes an unseen presence, glimpsed in fragments among documents, registers, photographs and living people.

The Small-Scale Setting of Madhav Communication Services

The small shop by the bus stand contains a cracked screen, charger cables, a betel tin, an old ledger and a blue signboard. These material details ground the apparently immaterial image of "digital" crime. When collections of customer forms, thumb impressions, SIM activation and the return of handsets all converge in a single place, the reader sees how an extensive network of threats might run through ordinary, small-scale services. The setting is modest; its possible consequences are considerable. That contrast gives fear a credible physical shape.

Madhav's Admission: The Cover of Ignorance and the Limits of Responsibility

Madhav says that people from the Harihar Service Centre brought him documents and that he believed they belonged to a welfare camp. The narrator records his tears and admissions without treating them as the end of all responsibility. Meera distinguishes ignorance from the disclosure of truth. Through this character, the novel examines the complicated position of a low-level intermediary within institutional deception: the work passed through his hands, but whether he knew the direction and extent of the entire network remains a question requiring investigation.

The Red Box and a Child's Unexpected Revelation

A casual question from Madhav's nephew brings a red box out from beneath the table. This is a consequential narrative turn, for the mystery is advanced not through a specialist's difficult explanation but through an object a child has noticed in everyday life. Empty SIM envelopes, clippings

and an old photograph of Ramratiya Devi are found inside. A child's perspective becomes an active part of social investigation. Yet finding the box does not automatically establish a criminal connection for every paper it contains; the author proceeds through successive stages of evidence.

The Dead Ramratiya Devi's Name: An Impossible Conjunction of Times

Ramratiya Devi died two years earlier, yet her photograph appears among the SIM distribution papers. Past death thus collides with present digital activity. The proposition "a living threat in a dead person's name" is not simply a miraculous image; it reworks the earlier episode of "the consent of the dead." This parallel makes documentary forgery and telephone fraud two forms of a more fundamental appropriation. The name of someone whose body is no longer present can still be reused, and the dignity of mourning converted into an economic instrument.

Bishambhar's Arrival: A Defensive Performance of Arrogance

Bishambhar arrives on a motorcycle with two young men, sees the red box and mocks the investigation as a trivial matter. The lightness of his words contrasts with his visible agitation. He begins making a video, but Devika starts reading out the place, time, people present and details of the motorcycle. The scene's dramatic mechanism is not physical confrontation but a reversal of observation. The man who intended to intimidate others with a camera becomes the subject of a time-stamped description himself.

A Signature-Like Line: The Distance between Resemblance and Identification

Madhav's ledger contains a crooked line resembling Bishambhar's signature, but Bishambhar denies having signed it. The narrator does not convert a similar shape into definitive identification. The line is a lead for investigation, not a judicial finding. This distance is essential: criticism must not make suspicion into proof, but examine the route the narrative takes from suspicion. The restraint slows the immediate action before an angry crowd, while intensifying the ethical tension.

Ordered Lines of Speakers: An Alternative to a Crowd

Once the crowd gathers, Meera organises speakers into two lines and sets out a sequence of questions: names, dates of thumb impressions, who instructed them to obtain SIMs, and whether they received phones. "The people" cease to be an undifferentiated crowd and become individuals who speak. The eight recorded names include different circumstances—death, illness, residence away from home and old age. A collective picture of possible wrongdoing emerges without erasing the specificity of each

person. The density of events is produced not simply by the number of names but by the management of testimony.

Ownership of Evidence: The Red Box Remains in the Shop

Meera does not seize the red box. The original remains secured in Madhav's shop, while an inventory, photographs and witnesses' signatures are prepared. Here the narrative's ethical method becomes a visible action. If an effort opposed to the theft of names simply takes materials at will, it risks reproducing the methods of those it accuses. The relationship between the original object and its documentary copy is therefore repeatedly clarified. Such care may lessen the speed of suspense, but it strengthens the reasoning on which credibility depends.

From the Grandmother's Photograph to the Grandson's Voice

After Ramratiya Devi's photograph is shown, her grandson's protest carries the narrative from digital identification back to family memory. The photograph once appeared to claim official recognition of a benefit; now it suggests the use of a name after death. The grandson's voice changes the object's significance. In the original novel, the younger generation is not merely the victim's representative. It turns a past humiliation into a public question in the present. Inherited memory forms part of the inquiry's context; it does not become an omniscient narrator.

From the SIM's Shadow to the Service Centre: A Transition

In the closing section, the investigators resolve to compare the Harihar Service Centre's register, camp photographs, phone-distribution list and the number used to issue threats. The SIM's shadow has not yet taken bodily form, but an institutional location is being identified. Drumbeats can be heard towards Dhruvesh's mansion; some characters interpret them as connected with the crime, but that connection is not a confirmed fact. Such an auditory suspicion directs the reader towards the next chapter, "The Door of the Harihar Service Centre." The chapter leaves a question, not a fabricated solution.

Critical Section 283 | Original Chapter 182 — The Door of the Harihar Service Centre

The Mask of Welfare: Daytime Service and Night-Time Accounts

The chapter's title turns the service centre's doorway into the meeting point of two different times. During the day there are claims of pensions, phones, beneficiary registers and public service; at night there are SIM cards, returned phones, the suspicious use of accounts and a possible network of unknown numbers. The narrator's criticism is directed not against the word "service" in itself, but against the dual manner in which an institution may employ it. The very premises that attract people seeking assistance can also facilitate the careless collection of their trust. This contradiction gives the setting an ironic character.

Narhari Kaka's Key: The Extraordinary Role of an Ordinary Caretaker

Narhari Kaka, who keeps the old key to the service centre, becomes important to the sequence of inquiry. Despite the absence of high rank, his memory of the premises, his recognition of objects and his experience of the sounds made by its equipment later provide decisive clues. The key is more than an instrument for opening a door: the story shows that someone who maintains a building from day to day may also be a living repository of its suppressed history. As with Bhikhari Lal's perspective as an attendant in earlier chapters, Narhari's presence brings lower-status labour to the centre of testimony.

The Crowd at the Door and the Discipline of Questions

When the list of names is opened, older people, women and labourers begin offering different complaints. The narrative creates the possibility of spontaneous agitation, but Meera separates the questions into distinct categories: verification of names, whether any benefit was received, whether a thumb impression was obtained after the document was explained, and whether the phone was returned. This classification turns the crowd's indefinite noise into specific statements. Different kinds of possible irregularity emerge within the same welfare camp. Numbers and categories do not efface human experience here; they make its contradictions clearer.

The Language of Documents and the Body of the Thumbprint

The modern terms printed on the centre's forms do not correspond to the domestic language of those affected. People report that thumb impressions were taken in the name of photographs or pensions, but that the records later acquired other meanings connected with phone distribution or

banking services. The narrator uses this difference to expose the distance between written "consent" and actual understanding. A thumbprint is a bodily mark, yet as the context of a form changes it can begin to operate as an authority detached from the person who supplied it. The novel criticises this discordant exercise of control.

Bishambhar at the Door: The Visual Management of Fear

Bishambhar, previously seen at the SIM shop, remains connected with the service-centre narrative. His presence, the nervousness of assistants and the protection of questionable papers serve as links in the plot. But his presence does not establish that he personally directed every irregularity. Instead of announcing a criminal verdict, Meera orders the facts concerning where objects were found, the dates in the register and the witnesses' accounts. The moral strength of this social mystery lies partly in that restraint.

Photographs of Giving Phones and the Experience of Taking Them Back

Testimony emerges that people were handed phones for photographs at a public-service camp, only for the phones to be taken back afterwards. In the photograph, the moment "benefit received" is fixed in place; in a person's experience, the object did not remain. The narrative probes the distance between image and event. A publicity photograph displays one instant, whereas whether the benefit endures is determined in time beyond its frame. This distinction digitally reworks the earlier sequence of theatrical performance and the work hidden behind the stage.

Ramratiya's Absence: Reconstructing a Presence in the Narrative

The deceased Ramratiya Devi cannot be physically present at the centre during the investigation. Nevertheless, her photograph, the SIM register, her grandson Deepak's recollections and the surviving phone-related materials construct new testimony around an absent body. The narrator does not bring her back to physical life through a miracle. Instead, the persistence of her name in circulation reveals an irony of appropriation. The magical-realist resonance is an emotional echo of social humiliation, not a substitute for verification.

The Appearance of the Pen Drive: Another Step in the Chain of Objects

Inside the centre, a pen drive marked "Camp Photographs" is found. Meera resists the temptation to open it immediately and draws attention to the need to establish the time, witnesses and method of copying. This object becomes the digital successor to the "closed chest" of the plot. In earlier chapters, an iron chest, a discarded sack and a consent notebook

contained mysteries; now a small device may hold numerous images and recordings. The narrative object's physical scale contracts while the possible extent of its contents expands.

The Limits Set by Permission: A Human Discipline for Digital Inquiry

In discussing the pen drive, photographs, beneficiaries' identities and the keeping of copies, the narrative repeatedly insists that seeing evidence and publicising it are different acts. Meera prevents the private pain of any person from being displayed before the crowd. This recurrence is deliberate, even if it momentarily slows the chapter's tension. Because the fraudsters themselves have already used names and photographs without meaningful understanding or consent, the investigation's ethical difference must appear in its control over the material it collects.

Progress in the Inquiry: The Door Opens, the Face Remains Hidden

At the final public gathering, a list of register entries, copies of receipts for returned phones and an account of the sealed pen drive are placed near Channa Grove. Reaching the institution represents progress, but the individual roles and flow of data within it are still only partially understood. The original text itself acknowledges this incompleteness. The reader first experiences the symbolic satisfaction of an "opened door," then realises that the sealed device's contents will become the object of the next chapter. In this way the novel sustains a sequence of memory from one object to another.

The Folk Song's Dawn and the Prose's Dusk

The opening folk song calls for the service door to be opened at dawn and its lock removed with the key of the people's speech. The principal narrative moves through a day of inquiry towards the sealing of evidence at dusk and a gathering at night. There is a subtle distance between the song's imagined collective illumination and the prose's cautious, incomplete disclosure. The author does not stop at the direct conclusion of a victory song; compiling a factual inventory has value only if it is compared with further material. The declarative energy of the style and the uncertainty of events thereby test one another.

Critical Section 284 | Original Chapter 183 — The Face Inside the Phone

The Pen Drive's Seal: The Body of a Digital Archive

The chapter opens with the service centre's small pen drive. It is not merely a digital repository but also a sealed physical object on which dew settles and whose opening is said to require witnesses. The author thereby places modern data within the material tradition of old ledgers and locked chests. More important than the display of scientific terminology is the recognition that disrupting the order in which material is handled may destroy confidence in the truth it is claimed to contain. Vineet Jha's making of a copy becomes the first event of disclosure.

Folder Names: A Sequence Written by the Alleged Crime Itself

"Camp Photographs," "Documents," "Beneficiary List," "Returned Phones" and "Special": these folder names function like a miniature narrative sequence within the story. They successively uncover collective display, personal identity, the return of objects and a hidden web of recorded voices. The apparently ordinary administrative word "Special" contains a potentially darker layer of wrongdoing. The reader anticipates the next folder, while the material in each one and the statements of affected people remain on different evidentiary levels. This organisation prevents the chapter from fragmenting into isolated discoveries.

Ramratiya's Photograph: The Politics of Centre and Margin

The service-camp photograph presents a banner, smiles and the spectacle of benefits distributed to a group; Devika notices Bishambhar standing at the edge. Ramratiya Devi looks not towards the camera but towards the paper. The opposition reveals the visual politics of the photograph: what organisers wish to display at the centre may be challenged by an unease recorded at the margins. Ramratiya's awkward gesture as she holds the phone resists the officially constructed image of achievement. The photograph is not itself a definitive accusation, but it creates questions for witnesses.

The Photograph's Timestamp: Three Records Meet

Aruni finds that the time of the photograph, the date in Madhav's SIM-activation register and the first entry in a bank message fall around the same date. The narrator treats this triangulation as an important advance. An isolated photograph might be ambiguous; when three different records converge in time, the question becomes more pointed. Even so, matching

dates do not automatically establish every component of an offence. Meera's and Satyavrat's cautious reactions preserve this awareness.

A Video of Returned Phones: Publicity Time versus the Object's Time

A video is found in which phones, publicly photographed in beneficiaries' hands, subsequently return to the hands of the centre's employees. In narrative terms, the interval between these two frames calls the entire public scheme into question. The first frame declares the act of "giving"; the second shows the informal act of "taking back." Their visual sequence gives new context to some people's oral complaints. Meera sets limits upon permission to view and circulate the video, so that the power of the image does not again take possession of those harmed.

The Same Handwriting: A Human Hand inside Digital Forms

The scanned forms display similar ticks, handwriting and mistakes: an incorrect marital status under widow benefits, a child's photograph in a pension record, and a farmer's account entered under a scholarship. These details raise the question of administrative carelessness versus possible systematic deception. The author makes the hurried work of human hands visible inside the machine's impersonal reproductions. Vineet explains that comparison of handwriting will require the original sheets. That condition holds the excitement of inference alongside the need for material verification.

Somri Kaki's Tears: Suffering within the Record

A recording in the "Special" folder carries Somri Kaki's frightened voice. What was an object of technical examination suddenly becomes the suffering of a living woman. A fragment of sound used by wrongdoers to create fear becomes, in a community gathering, an indication of trauma. Rather than immediately sending a crowd to her, Meera asks two women to seek her permission. Here the politics of listening becomes clear: gaining access to evidence does not confer ownership over another person's pain.

A Blurred Face, a Clear Hand: Uncertain Visual Identification

The face in a video is indistinct, but a wrist with a black thread, a long nail and a wound beside a ring are visible. Similar marks on the hand of Dhruvesh's assistant in an older public-gathering photograph attract the reader's attention. This is a striking reversal between the absence of a face and the visibility of a hand. Instead of a person's name, the novel places an organ of action at its narrative centre. Nevertheless, to regard a similar wrist or wound as definitive legal identification would go beyond the evidence. The reader must remain at the level of suspicion.

Laughter and the Fan's Creak: Sounds beyond the Frame

Somri Kaki recalls a suppressed laugh behind a threat; Narhari Kaka recognises the distinctive creaking of the service centre's fan. Through these minute sounds, the inquiry passes beyond the limits of the eye into the domain of hearing. Sound becomes an independent narrative object. A photograph supplies an appearance, while the rhythm of laughter suggests a person's habit or a possible location. Yet the narrator does not combine these identifications into an unambiguous unmasking. Background noise becomes the clue to a subsequent event.

Deepak's Silence: Inheritance rather than Spectacle

On seeing the photograph of his grandmother Ramratiya, the grandson Deepak withdraws. He later says that today he saw not his grandmother's face, but the theft of her name. His response prevents the chapter from becoming a cold exercise in technical investigation. A family's suffering does not produce the spectator's pleasure; it provokes shame and anger across generations. Meera gives disciplined support to this anger. The child's presence repeatedly indicates that narrative continuity here concerns not only the detection of crime but also the inheritance of collective memory.

A Face Half-Revealed at the End: The Ethical Deferral of Mystery

The chapter ends by placing the hand, laughter, fan, dates and victim's voice along one line of inquiry. The complete face remains unidentified, but the next title, “The Mask of the Voice,” comes into view. This is not an ending without direction: the narrative pauses at a carefully measured state of incompleteness. Each object gives rise to a new question. Even after the digital chest has been opened, the characters do not abandon restraint. Such an ethical deferral of mystery is the principal formal achievement of this section.

Critical Section 285 | Original Chapter 184 — The Mask of the Voice

The Return of Listening: From Visual Evidence to an Auditory Perspective

Chapter 183 gave prominence to photographs, fingerprints and device timestamps; in Chapter 184, the characters listen to rhythms of speech, breathing, laughter and the fan's three interruptions. The narrator thus changes the sensory field of testimony. Although the words of the telephone threats are in Hindi, local patterns of pronunciation become grounds for further inquiry. Vineet Jha's warning, however—that ears are emotional and instruments fallible—restrains the narrative excitement. Voice comparison provides a direction for investigation, not immediate and certain identification. Listening itself becomes a literary act.

The Practice of "Re-Check": A Theatre School for Fraud

The pen drive's "Re-Check" material contains repeated lines, performed in several voices, about police officers, bank inspections and imminent arrests. Through this repetition, fraud ceases to appear as a single phone call and becomes a rehearsed performance. In the earlier Videha Theatre Festival, acting enabled the audience to become witnesses; here actor-like voices induce people to obey instructions in isolation. Through this reversed relation, the novel reactivates its broader theatrical metaphor. The roles change, and the moral purpose of performance is inverted.

"I Have Received the Benefit": The Sound of Compelled Consent

Somri Kaki says that at the service camp she was made to repeat "I have received the benefit" three times, although the words did not reflect her actual condition. The short sentence becomes an auditory version of the older practice of recording false consent on paper. Within the imposed utterance, the relation between body, will and supposed achievement is severed. The author shows how a person's own voice can be detached from its meaning and made into a commodity. Through this subtle violence, the digital episode remains connected to the earlier fraud involving land.

The Old Video of the Service Ceremony: The Return of Time

Devika remembers an older video of the ceremony in which a young man beside the stage directed beneficiaries through the order of photographs and thumb impressions. That pattern is now compared with pauses between words in the fraudulent telephone calls. A public performance from the past becomes active again in the present inquiry.

Reinterpretation of the older scene brings a new insight to memory. But a similar habit of pronouncing the word "first" is a lead, not a definitive identification; Satyavrat explicitly adds that qualification.

Narhari's Fan: Local Knowledge of an Object's Sound

Narhari Kaka recognises the old service-centre fan's "ghurr-ghurr-khat" rhythm and recalls that one of its blades was bent. The detail matters: local knowledge acquired through ordinary maintenance enters the analysis of a digital recording. The technical officer Vineet Jha and Narhari do not represent competing forms of hearing, but complementary capacities. The fan is not merely background decoration; its interrupted sound provides a possible path between alleged sites of wrongdoing. It would be mistaken to treat this as complete modern laboratory proof, but its subtlety as a narrative clue deserves recognition.

Bishambhar's "Sir": The Dramatic Power of a Single Word

From the phone held by Bishambhar, standing at the back of the crowd, comes the word "sir." It is a tiny sound, yet the reader senses a wider structure of authority behind it. The character's fear, his haste to disconnect the call and the unread number compound the uncertainty. The narrator does not present a one-word clue as if it were a lengthy confession of crime. Vineet records the time, not a conclusion. The dramatic scene draws its effectiveness from this controlled silence.

The Fan's Possible Journey: A Mobile Architecture of Sound

According to Narhari, the old fan may have been taken to the city. Satyavrat draws a line connecting the service camp, voice samples, returned phones and a threatening-call room in the city. The narrator uses a sound to draw a spatial map. Ordinarily documents or travellers move from place to place; here a sound tells the story of an object's possible journey. Yet the transfer of the fan has not been established through a complete material chain. For criticism, the distinction between a possible route and a verified event is particularly important.

Permission for Women's Voices: The Victim's Right to Speak

The women present are angry when they hear names in the recorded threats, but Vineet and Meera do not compel them to make fresh voice recordings. A page of "voice testimony" is compiled only from willing speakers. The scene extends the narrative's earlier privacy principles to another sense: like a face, a voice belongs to an individual. The author's concern is not simply to uncover the fraudsters' technique, but to restore control over testimony to those whose voices have been appropriated.

Bishambhar's Partial Admission: A Layered Role within Wrongdoing

At night Bishambhar admits that he connected numbers, answered phones and sometimes rehearsed his voice on the instructions of a city-based "master." This admission indicates an active role within the operation, but it does not establish the master's true name, the full chain of orders or the division of financial proceeds. Self-defence and signs of involvement coexist in his statement. The crowd becomes agitated, and Meera intervenes. Through this tension, the novel draws a boundary between the drama of confession and the sequence required for justice.

The Dark Ghost and the Mechanical Witch: A New Translation of Folk Imagination

An old man compares the voice-changing tricks of traditional witch stories with counterfeit voices made by machines. The comparison does not seek to declare a technological phenomenon supernatural fact; it translates modern fear into the language of folk narrative. Metaphors such as a dark ghost and a pale apparition again frame a moral opposition. Through these images, the story offers older communities of listeners a shared imaginative language for understanding a new danger. Dates in registers and the identification of voices nevertheless remain matters for separate investigation.

The First Naming of the "Master": Setting Out for the Next Room

The chapter's concluding achievement is not the complete removal of a voice's mask but the first unmistakable appearance of the word "master." Bishambhar's hand with its black thread, the fan's sound, the rehearsal slip and the laughter of someone in the city together suggest the outline of an unidentified organiser. Ananya writes the title of the next page: "The Master's Room." This handover of a title sustains the serial rhythm of an expansive novel. The next event will be the search for the physical location of the alleged operation, not the arrest of an already identified offender. The distinction must remain clear.

Critical Section 286 | Original Chapter 185 — The Master's Room

Following the Creak: From the Office to Behind the Station

After the word "master" enters the investigation, the group searches for a room near the city's railway tracks. At the chapter's opening, the whirr, whirr, clatter of a fan draws the memory of Channa Grove towards a concrete urban location. Through this acoustic thread, the author contracts geographical distance: river, bus, market and station become

parts of a single landscape of inquiry. The fan's sound increasingly guides the narrative. Yet hearing a sound is not equivalent to identifying or apprehending a person; the original text consistently preserves the distance between a clue and a conclusive identification.

The Objects in the Room: A Site for Manufacturing Fear

The slips, recorder, voice rehearsals and telephone-related materials found in the room behind the station transform the chapter from a story of a list of victims into an account of the production of fear. It describes attempts to recreate an individual's voice in the guise of a father, an official, a banker or a police officer. The true horror of the plot lies not in the screen itself but in the unauthorised reuse of human trust. The room is less a museum of devices than a place where relationships are illicitly edited. The author's technical description remains inseparable from the suffering of the characters.

"Mādhavesh" or "Madhavesh": A Single Vowel in a Name

The difference between the forms "माधवेश" (Mādhavesh) and "मधवेश" (Madhavesh), emerging from the room's records, constitutes a significant instability of naming. The narrator treats a change in one vowel as a possible means of concealing identity across a register, a rent ledger and travel documents. Nevertheless, every difference in spelling is not, by itself, evidence of conspiracy: Maithili–Hindi transcription or an administrative mistake may also explain it. The criticism preserves those alternatives, showing how the narrative converts multiple forms of a character's name into investigative suspense without assuming in advance that every reference denotes the same person.

The Sound of the Station: Structuring Time in Motion

The locomotive's whistle, the vibration of the tracks and the room's fan become another kind of clock. When a train passes, the room trembles; the small objects and slips within it are experienced differently at that instant. The author brings the question "when?" alongside "where?" Once a name in a rent ledger, a date belonging to a particular night and a traveller's recollection are placed together, time itself becomes a narrative scene. This acoustic arrangement quickens the reader's pace, although the final reconciliation of evidence is still required.

From Bishambhar's Presence to the Absent Master

Bishambhar provides details of the route, the room and its equipment, but the master does not yet appear in full before the investigators. Bishambhar's partial information combines apparent reliability with self-protection. The narrator refuses to make the scene a simple climax of

arrest; instead, the narrative follows the objects left in the room, the old registers and a receding shadow. An absent person becomes increasingly present through material traces. This paradox lends force to the title: the "master's room" has been found, but the "master" remains smoke.

Hearing the Fan Again: Avoiding Unwarranted Certainty in Testimony

Narhari recognises a particular manner in which a fan runs, and this sound is compared with a telephone recording. Here the author places the experienced human ear beside mechanical listening. Yet similar sounds can arise from different sources. A responsible reading therefore treats the fan not as a definitive legal identification but as a sustained thread of resonance within the narrative. The narrator fashions a gradual acquisition of credibility: the fan is first heard, then its possible movement is considered, then the room is questioned, and only after that does the inquiry turn to the spelling of a name.

The Theatre of Counterfeit Authority: The Irony of "Master"

In ordinary social usage, "master" can be an honorific for a teacher, a giver of knowledge or someone who trains others. Here the same word designates a figure who directs the rehearsal of sentences designed to cause fear. This reversal of meaning forms the centre of the chapter's irony. The trainer in deception shapes vocal rhythms as though imposing school discipline, but his lessons aim to suppress the victim's independent judgement. At the earlier theatre festival, performance was intended to awaken the right to testify; here rehearsal serves to steal the right to one's voice. The opposition establishes a long internal echo across the novel.

The Two Paths of Devices and Papers

The room is a site for experimenting with voices, but its operations cannot be separated from SIM registers, trust accounts and old office papers. Although the episode initially seems to introduce a new kind of cybercrime, it remains grounded in institutional memory. The narrator does not reduce the perpetrator to electronic expertise alone: assigned roles, resources, older social hierarchies and the surrounding climate of fear all matter. The room is not a place of technological isolation; it is a meeting point of different media and systems.

The Master's Absence: The Stretching of Narrative Time

Upon discovering the room, the reader might expect the criminal's face to be revealed immediately. Instead, the story extends the puzzle of names, rent registers and journeys beyond the city. This postponement could be a sound strategy of suspense if the later chapters supply the missing details.

For now, only one point is secure: “master” has become the name of a role. Which individual occupies it, how that person was appointed and for how many offences they are responsible remain separate questions. The critic's task is not to compress these three inquiries into a single, falsely conclusive name.

Returning from the Railway Tracks to the Village: Restoring the Centre

After the urban investigation, the narration returns to the memory of Channa Grove and to communal reading. This cyclical structure is a defining feature of the novel: every external search eventually enters the community's shared register. The city thus does not acquire exclusive ownership of the investigation; the village remains the ethical listener to its findings. The room outside is the physical site of events, whereas Channa Grove becomes their critical classroom. Through this repetition, spatial continuity and the widening reach of events coexist.

Identifying the Next Name: From a Half-Opened Room to a Life Story

The chapter ultimately concentrates on the forms of name used by the “master.” A new question emerges beyond the techniques of issuing threats: out of which social memory did this person arise, and why was the name changed? The following chapter, “Madhavesh's Real Name,” is therefore a natural transition. The story prepares to bring biography into contact with the mechanics of wrongdoing. Investigating a name is not the final unlocking of a confession; a life story may introduce historical layers of conscience, social shame and opportunity.

Critical Section 287 | Original Chapter 186 — Madhavesh's Real Name

Four Forms of One Name: The Narrative Sequence of Identity

An old school register, an image from a theatrical performance, a scholarship form, a rent ledger and people's recollections together suggest a sequence: Madhukar Madhav Mishra, Mādhavesh, Madhavesh and Master. Within this sequence a name is not unchanging proof of identity but a social role altered over time. The village child, the migrant to the city, the technical instructor and the apparent performer within a criminal network may be linked to the same person. The narrator makes the name not merely a clue in a mystery but a fragmented order of biography.

The School Register: The Earlier Life Behind an Urban Mask

Behind the city's criminal activity the story reads an old school roll and pages relating to a scholarship. This shift in time seeks to illuminate the suspected offender's early life. Like the survey register from fifteen years before, school papers bring the past back into the present. Nevertheless, a childhood aptitude for imitating voices does not itself predict future criminal conduct; the narrative investigates the historical route by which a skill might have been misused. The distinction between talent, opportunity and subsequent decisions is essential to a critical reading.

The Old Theatre Photograph: The Difference Between Art and Deception

The description of a child's practice in changing voices on stage creates a memory-link to the imitation of voices used in modern threats. Through this connection, the earlier Videha Theatre Festival regains critical significance. Art enlarges human experience; when the same skill is put to work selling fear, however, its intention is reversed. The narrator does not treat acting as intrinsically criminal. Rather, its ethical meaning is determined by the spectators' consent and the purpose of the performance. It would be misleading to draw a straight, deterministic line from the child's art to the adult's fraud.

The Neighbour Woman's Memory: A Source of Informal History

A neighbour's account, memories of the mother's earlier conduct and a half-written sentence in charcoal upon a wall give emotional depth to the school documents. The character's social history is composed not only of official records but also of household silences, neighbours' testimony and shame. The narrator accords importance to modest witnesses. Yet the

authorship of the charcoal writing remains uncertain; this object is not definitive evidence of the accused person's later psychology but an evocative expression of communal memory.

"Do Not Sell Your Voice": The Counter-Voice of the Mother

The surviving words "Do not sell your voice" on an old wall create a striking ethical counter-image. A person whose alleged criminal technique trades in voices has, in an early remembered setting, encountered a prohibition against selling them. The contradiction separates the character from a simplified, monstrous portrait. The skill of voice was once a means of recognition within society and later may have become a means of illicit income: the story outlines the sorrowful possibility of such a transformation. Yet the author of the inscription has not been confirmed. The narrative leaves this uncertainty open for reflection.

Bishambhar's Account: The Desire to Rename Oneself

Bishambhar says that the master associated his old name "Madhukar" with poverty, the village and memories of his mother, whereas "Madhavesh" lent him the appearance of respectable urban credibility. In this account, changing one's name becomes a linguistic performance of social shame. But Bishambhar is himself an implicated character who has offered only an incomplete admission. His explanation is a particular source of testimony, not the author's final omniscient judgement. Maintaining that distinction prevents a narrative of personal shame from obscuring responsibility for wrongdoing.

"Madhukar" and the Sound of Bees: The Birth of a Symbol

The name Madhukar gives rise to the buzzing of bees and to metaphors of honey and poison. In the twilight scenes of the grove, invisible bees are discussed within the characters' folk imagination. "Honey" comes to signify sweet social trust, while "poison" suggests its exploitative use. The narrator is not reporting an actual incident of beekeeping. Instead, the resonance of a name prepares the next chapter's title, "The Queen Inside the Hive." This acoustic transition establishes a new family of symbols within the long, interconnected narrative.

Confirmation Still Required: The Incomplete Map of a Life

Vineet's diagram puts the Master, the Harihar Service Centre, Dhruvesh's network, the room by the station and the SIM–trust connection into a sequence. Yet it also records the absence of confirmation regarding Maheshwar's role, the flow of money through the bank and the travel links. That explicit incompleteness matters. Despite the title "Real Name,"

the chapter does not produce a final indictment; it constructs a strong possibility of identity. Legal certainty and the literary unveiling of a mystery occupy different levels.

Deepak's Question: A Criminal Role-Name versus a Personal Name

Deepak asks why the person should be called Master if he is Madhukar. Meera replies by urging a distinction among official identification, the name current in popular memory and the role a person plays in the suspected crime. The child's straightforward question becomes an instrument of narrative theory: a name is not merely a sound, for its meaning alters across social contexts. The narrator avoids imposing a single omniscient designation and preserves the character's varied relationships. Multiple naming also carries a political implication, since changing a name can change where accountability is directed.

Madhukar's Absence: A Biography Available, a Person Unseen

Even when the school papers, photograph and rent ledger begin to correspond, Madhukar does not appear in full, direct presence. A tension remains at the centre of the story between an absent body and present records. The distance separating the child of the past, the Master of the present and a possible organiser reminds the reader that a person is constructed through multiple accounts. The narrative has not yet reached the financial summit of the alleged wrongdoing. This incomplete biography produces the question of the following chapter: where is the poisonous honey stored?

The Next Hive: From Personal Identity to Structural Power

At the end, the old ghost offers a metaphor: catching a single bee does not stop the entire network. The image expresses the tension between the desire to apprehend an individual and the wider reach of an institutional operation. The next title, “The Queen Inside the Hive,” opens another centre of inquiry: where do the profits from the voices produced by the Master go, and in whose name do they arrive? The narrative thus turns naturally from a person's name to the investigation of financial cover.

Critical Section 288 | Original Chapter 187 — The Queen Inside the Hive

The Beehive: A Misleading Feminine Form of a Name

The word “queen” might readily lead a reader to expect an individual female offender. At the beginning of the chapter, Meera explicitly insists that no woman should be accused on the basis of such an assumption. This prohibition protects the distinction between a symbol and an actual character. Madhukar's honey, the hive's accumulated wealth and the queen's commands raise questions of financial control, but “queen” has not been established as any person's name. That subtle distinction becomes an ethical foundation of the narrative.

“Flower–Honey–Queen”: The Structure Named by the Criminal Operation

A chart found among the Master's equipment places SIM cards, voices, photographs and beneficiaries under “flower”; amounts and deductions under “honey”; and various codes and references to a trust under “queen.” These three divisions are not merely metaphors invented by the author; they are labels discovered within the fictional world itself. The story also shows criminals adopting attractive metaphors to describe their activities. “Flower” becomes a source of victims' names, “honey” the money extracted from them, and “queen” a cover for that money. Violent uses lurk behind each beautiful term.

From Small Transfers to a Large Accumulation: The Rise of Financial Time

An officer from the digital-crime branch identifies a sequence in which small transfers are followed by a large amount deposited on a single day. Without the use of a graph, this financial ascent creates a climax. The volume of money gives material weight to the poetic metaphor of the hive. Yet tracing the movement of funds and identifying their ultimate owner remain distinct tasks. The narrator places the movement of money first, the account holder's identity next, and the source of instructions thereafter. Through that sequence, the financial mystery acquires the extended dimensions of a long novel.

Rani Devi's Home: From a Bank Image to a Living Person

The name of seventy-two-year-old Rani Devi, from Haripur Katan, appears on an account. The crowd's first reaction is suspicious, but the investigators visit her home and find an elderly woman drying grain. The

distance between the person named in a ledger and the woman seated upon sand beside discarded medicine wrappers is dramatic. The scene confronts suspicion based on figures with a person's embodied circumstances. Differences between the form of her thumb impression and the mark on the account then become genuine questions for investigation. The narrative itself prevents her from being declared a criminal merely because her name appears there.

Three Uses of a Thumbprint on the Pretext of a "Faulty Machine"

Rani Devi's grandson says that at the service centre his grandmother's thumb was placed on a glass surface three times because she was told the machine had malfunctioned. His account exposes the cruel difference between technical assistance and the potential misuse of biometric identification. The narrator opens the event through the child's memory without presenting a complete technical reconstruction of the device as proven fact. Even with that caution, the scene's social meaning is sharp: the elderly woman could not control the technological use made of her own name and identity.

Rani Kumari and the Paper Committee: Many Bodies Behind One Name

Another occurrence of "Rani" refers to Rani Kumari, who had left her home region; a third is the "Rani Women's Assistance Committee," whose actual office premises remain doubtful. By placing the three names together, the author shows how separate documentary entities can operate behind the same word. It becomes impossible to treat the figurative "queen" as one unnamed woman guilty of the offences. The narrative turn shifts attention from the person allegedly committing the crime to the institutional use of women's names.

Bishambhar's Statement and Maheshwarnath Sevak

Bishambhar says that "Rani" was not a name selected by the Master, but one introduced on the instructions of Maheshwar Babu, a figure higher up. An image of the committee's register bears the name "Maheshwarnath Sevak, Convenor," along with a blue seal. Taken together, these two sources clarify the direction of the previously uncertain reference to "Maheshwar." Still, Bishambhar's statement and the designation in the register do not conclusively establish that Maheshwarnath controlled the whole financial offence. The author's staged disclosure reaches a new height while retaining the gaps in the investigation.

The Structural Critique of Turning Women's Names into Instruments

Earlier thefts of names involved papers belonging to the dead and telephone SIM cards; now they reach an elderly woman, a migrant young woman and the cover of a women's organisation. Through Bishambhar's account emerges the suggestion that offenders regarded women's respectability, literacy and social standing as a safe shield. This is a distinct form of gendered exploitation: the woman is kept in the background while her name is made to act in public. Meera prepares a list of names to be cleared so that the investigation does not itself produce another act of violence through false accusation.

Catching the Offender and Protecting the Innocent Name: Two Times of the Story

Rani Devi's grandson asks that his grandmother's name be cleared. His request divides the future time of punishment from the present time of dignity. Finding the actual controller of the fraud may take time, but the social cost of suspicion attached to an innocent person's name is payable immediately. The introduction of a "name-clearing list" therefore creates a new narrative institution. Even when the assembly at Channa Grove cannot pronounce a judicial verdict, it can publicly act to restore an injured person's identity.

Dark and Pale Ghosts and the Hive: The Coexistence of Imagination and Inquiry

At night in the grove, descriptions of dark ghosts, pale apparitions and buzzing make the moral darkness of the suspected wrongdoing visible. Alongside them, however, are Rani's account, her grandson's statement, comparison of thumb impressions and the committee register—physical materials belonging to different categories of fact within the investigation. Magical realism does not add evidentiary proof here; it intensifies the experience of intergenerational fear and memory. Maintaining the distinction prevents the novel's supernatural dimension from displacing its social realism.

The Transition to "Maheshwar's Seal"

By the end of the chapter, Madhukar's production of voices, Dhruvesh's service network, the Rani accounts and Maheshwarnath's seal are placed in a conditional relationship. Ananya opens the next page under the heading "Maheshwar's Seal." The title signals that the actual chain of decisions within the financial hive has not yet been established. Rather than solve the riddle of "queen" through an invented certainty, the story preserves

the possibility that several women whose names were used are innocent, and turns towards the sources of the next signature and order.

Inter-Sectional Discussion: From the City's Accounts to the Queen Inside the Hive

Across the eight chapters from "The City's Accounts" to "The Queen Inside the Hive," the story both expands its geography and refines its evidence. The lines traced in the earth at Channa Grove appear in the city's accountant's ledger; the account number leads to a SIM-card shop near the bus stand; the SIM register opens a path through the pen drive at the Harihar Service Centre. From there the narrative proceeds from images to voices, from voices to a fan, from the fan to a room by the station, from that room to multiple names, and finally from those names to a financial hive. Each chapter ends by handing an object to the next. This succession of things sustains the breadth of the long narrative: rather than producing an entirely new incident, the story reveals the existing incident through one medium after another.

Time, too, operates in several layers. In the city's accounts, a date associated with land confronts the date of a trust payment; a SIM form connects a present threat to an old photograph of the deceased Ramratiya Devi; timestamps on relief-camp photographs are compared with bank messages; the Master's school register takes a suspected present offence back into childhood. Through these backward movements, time in the original novel ceases to be a mere succession of days and nights and becomes a rereading of memory. An object that once signified "donation" begins, in the investigation, to signify the "possible appropriation of rights." The author does not simply repeat events; the moment from which they are interpreted changes.

The distribution of narrative perspective is distinctive in this sequence. Shanti brings the soil of the fields into the city's accounts; Ananya records numbers, dates and the language of witnesses; Aruni asks about the gaps between signs; Devika examines the performative qualities of images and voices; Meera maintains the boundary between conjecture and established claims; and Satyavrat moves from the fatigue of older veranda proceedings towards the critical reading of modern archives. Narhari's memory of the fan and a simple question from Madhav's nephew break the monopoly of experts. The authority of narration is not concentrated in one omniscient hero but dispersed among social voices that examine one another.

The treatment of digital fraud has a particularly theatrical significance, though this discussion remains on the ground of narratology. Imitating the voice of a police officer, banker or son on the phone is an act of role-playing; rehearsing a "re-check" is directed dialogue; a fabricated image of assistance is a stage constructed for its viewer. Against these performances,

memory of the earlier Videha Theatre Festival creates an opposition: there, the spectator sought to become a witness, whereas here the victim's freedom to decide is suppressed. The contrast becomes a form of narrative self-reference. Similarity between performances alone, however, cannot establish that a particular character committed a crime.

A chain of object-metaphors runs through the eight chapters. Shanti's shawl gives bodily presence to the coldness of the trust's accounts; the red SIM box contains stolen names belonging to the dead; the pen drive is a digital strongbox; the fan's creaking is an acoustic footprint; the school register suggests an earlier possible identity of the "Master"; and the beehive images the complicated accumulation of profit. Crocodiles, dark ghosts and pale apparitions remain at the edge of this material world as moral echoes of the imagination. Poetry and imagery heighten the mental pressure of the wrongdoing, while the characters turn to separate registers and documents to establish physical facts.

Uncertainty is preserved structurally throughout. The full meaning of "Ra. Cha. La." remains unrevealed; the line resembling Bishambhar's signature is only a suspicion; the wound on a hand and the sound of a fan are indications requiring material comparison; and the difference between the name forms "Mādhavesh" and "Madhavesh" remains an identity question. Chapter 186 presents a strong biographical link with "Madhukar Madhav Mishra," while stating that Maheshwar's role, the trust and the flow of funds still require confirmation. Chapter 187 resists the easy impulse to turn the name "Rani" into an accusation against one woman. Clearing the names of Rani Devi, Rani Kumari and the paper committee's possible victims becomes an achievement of criticism within the story.

The lasting effect is less a declaration of judicial victory than the development of narrative responsibility. Not circulating a victim's photograph without permission, not compelling someone to record a new voice sample, preserving original records, and distinguishing what has been heard, seen and merely inferred are not just ethical speeches by characters: they are compositional principles governing how events unfold. The turn in Chapter 187 towards "Maheshwar's Seal" shows that the queen of the hive is not necessarily the final person in the operation; the search for the hands that constructed the hive remains. In that sense, the sequence ends not with closure but with responsible incompleteness.

Critical Section 289 | Original Chapter 188 — Maheshwar's Seal

The Metaphor of a Blue Wound at the Chapter's Opening

Chapter 187's multiple accounts under the name "Rani" suggested not the actual guilt of a woman but the possible exploitation of her identity. Chapter 188 takes the inquiry to the round blue seal of Maheshwarnath Sevak. The narrator makes the impression on the body of a sheet of paper into a "wound": the document is no longer an inert page but a body bearing the blows of history. The metaphor succeeds not simply because it provokes anger, but because it places before the reader the narrative relationship among three different papers bearing a similar mark.

A Joint Scene of Three Documents

Satyavrat Mehta lays the approval for the Rani Women's Assistance Committee, a training certificate from the Harihar Service Centre, and an introductory document for a joint bank account upon the same stone. The narrative camera rests not upon any one person's face but upon the matching seals of the three documents. Within the same circular impression appear the forms "Maheshwarnath," "Maheshwar Nath" and "M. N. Sevak." The visual similarity advances the investigation, yet the alternatives of an original seal, a copied mould or an impression subsequently recreated remain open.

From Mahesar to Maheshwar: Multiple Names

In Narhari Kaka's memory Maheshwar was known as "Mahesar" in childhood, then became "Maheshwar," "Maheshwarnath," and eventually took the designation "Sevak." Ananya records these names as a question of personal development or concealment. The sequence may tell a social story of self-making; it may equally serve as an instrument for disguising authority. The original text does not immediately declare one interpretation decisive. There is a parallel with Madhukar's change of name to "Madhavesh" in the previous chapter, but it would be a critical oversimplification to presume the two characters' motives identical.

Bajrang the Stamp-Maker: A Craftsman's Way of Seeing

Bajrang the stamp-maker is not a principal officer but an aged artisan from the old market. His hands tremble, yet his practised eye for the cutting of letters remains keen: bodily weakness is placed against the strength of skilled perception. He identifies the seal as produced from a machine-made mould rather than by hand, and points towards a possible place of manufacture in a lane behind the station. His recollection counts as a

source, but he is uncertain whether the apprentice involved was connected with Dhruv or Dhruvesh. The novel uses craftsmanship to raise questions, not to pronounce a legal conclusion.

Invoice Numbers and the Recurrence of Objects

The sequence of invoices numbered 446, 447 and 448, introduced by Vineet Jha, gives the chapter's suspense a concrete numerical discipline. Indications that a round seal, a smaller one and a committee seal were produced on the same day connect recurrent images to practical transactions. But the customer's designation is merely "Service Centre," and payment was made in cash. The invoices therefore do not, of themselves, prove that Maheshwar or Dhruvesh gave the order. The numbers form narrative steps along a possible route between the old lane of voice imitation and the present bank documents.

The Reversal of Time in the Papers

The bank introduction bears a seal dated five days before the approval letter. This is not simply a chronological inconsistency in the narrative's telling; it is an apparent documentary impossibility shown within the story itself, and the characters investigate it. The author turns time's straight line backwards: first the benefit or the account, and only later the paperwork authorising it. The possibility of such retrospective legitimisation suggests a crime in which words may be manufactured after the actions they purport to justify. Verification of the dates and documents nevertheless remains necessary.

Women's Testimony and the Dignity of Names

Women from three villages speak about experiences involving their names on committee papers, thumb impressions for ration supplies, a pretext of pension correction, and photographs said to be for their daughters' scholarships. The narrator does not use these statements to declare Maheshwar guilty at once; Meera safeguards each family's documents separately. Rani Devi's name had already been turned into financial cover, and the new testimony ties the blue impression to women's everyday hopes. The women are not objects in the story but speakers who examine what consent actually means.

The Unexpected Identification of a Keeper of Keys

An old donation register of the Harihar Service Centre identifies Maheshwarnath not as "Treasurer" but as "Keeper of Keys." This small change of designation redirects the reader's expectation. Suspicion moves from the person writing the accounts to someone holding objects and unused letterheads. In Narhari's recollection appear the institution's iron

chest, certificates signed before being filled in, and a practice of adding names afterwards. Within the narrative's causal sequence these are elements of foreshadowing whose material examination becomes the next chapter's task.

The Second Life of Blue Ink

Bajrang the stamp-maker explains that a particular blue ink used to be requested so that the impression would appear clearly in photographs. This observation connects the physical seal to the digital image. The seal may inspire authority not only on the original paper but also in an alleged order displayed on a telephone screen. Deepak asks whether the order appearing on his grandmother's phone carried the same seal. Yet the difference between Vineet's suggestion and Meera's insistence that comparison is still pending protects the reliability of the account. The medium changes; the social mechanism of fear created by an official-looking mark remains.

Gadadhar's Key: An Ethical Turn

Gadadhar, the former watchman, arrives leaning on a stick, says that the iron chest is still in the storeroom, and places a rusted key on the public stone. A man who had repeatedly claimed not to remember now produces an object himself. This narrative admission takes place not in a grand speech but in the small weight of a piece of metal. The ghosts bending towards the key belong to the scene of folk belief, whereas the practical decision is to secure the presence of the village council, police, bank representative and women's committee. The miraculous does not replace procedure.

The Final Question and the Passage to the Next Chapter

The chapter ends before the iron chest is opened. Three images—the blue wound, a green leaf and the rusted key—prepare the reader to enter the history of the seal. Although “Maheshwar” resembles the name of Maheshwar Mishra recorded in an earlier survey register, it has not been established that they are the same individual. The committee role of Maheshwarnath Sevak requires separate investigation. Preserving that uncertainty is the justifiable way to read both the novel's character construction and its conflicts among sources.

Critical Section 290 | Original Chapter 189 — The Iron Chest

The Public Opening at Dawn

The gaze that remained fixed on Gadadhar's key through the night turns, at the following dawn, into the opening of the storeroom. The narrative does not immediately proclaim victory. Instead, the presence of the panchayat, police, a bank representative, the women's committee and the children establishes an order of witnessing. Opening layer after layer also becomes the chapter's principle of composition: the door, sacks, chest, coconut leaves, blank letterheads, carbon copies, seals, fabricated thumb impressions and register. This sequence of discovered objects sustains the drama of mystery while requiring a separate interpretive caution at every new disclosure.

The Narrative Work of the Storeroom's Smell

As the door opens, the smells of cement sacks, rat droppings, dampness, oil and ink escape together. The narrator joins the sense of smell to sight, giving the institution's decayed past the character of a rotting body. On the chest marked 'सेवा' ('service'), the fact that 'वा' is almost erased is more than a decorative detail: it visually figures the incompleteness of the language of service. Yet the smell of decay is not itself proof of a crime. It shapes the reader's sensory response, while the papers found inside make an investigation into actual events possible.

The Inverted Sanctity of the Coconut Leaves

The chest's first layer contains dried coconut leaves, before any papers appear; yellow traces of turmeric remain on them. Narhari recalls the practice of placing an auspicious leaf upon old donation deeds. The religious object is not presented as the cause of the wrongdoing: the circumstances of its use are what must be examined. Without condemning an object of folk belief in itself, the novel shows how blank paper and unauthorised seals can lie beneath a covering marked as auspicious. Within the magical atmosphere, the object's double ethical significance lends the scene depth.

Blank Letterheads and Consent Given in Advance

The chest contains letterheads already signed or stamped, but with spaces in which names or dates could subsequently be filled in. Blankness itself emerges as part of a possible plan: an empty area on a page remains available for fabricating someone's later consent. This structurally repeats the earlier files in which 'temporary assistance' was transformed into

'permanent relinquishment'. The chapter exhibits the material apparatus for such a possible technique; it does not establish who supplied every signature on every sheet. That question demands a separate investigation.

The Counter-World of Carbon Copies

Blue-black carbon sheets stain the children's palms as they lift them. The same object can serve the convenience of copying and the deceit of producing a copy. Gadadhar's question—'Which is the original, and which is the copy?'—overturns the conventional hierarchy of records. The narrator makes the existence of multiple documentary versions more than a technical difficulty; it becomes a figure for parallel versions of the story. As readers attempt to distinguish original from reproduction, the characters search for the original wording of their history.

The Incomplete Page of Bisesar Paswan

A yellow envelope contains labourers' claims and old pages concerning assistance after the Ganga bridge disaster. Opposite Bisesar Paswan's incomplete name, the entry reads 'absence' rather than 'death'. With this difference of a single word, the original novel's account of water burial returns inside the chamber of contemporary fraud. A labourer who lost his life is given, in the record, the status of someone still living but absent. The chapter thus connects the old disaster to the new cybercrime; the writer of the entry, its beneficiary and the reason for its wording nevertheless remain unidentified.

Boxes of Seals and Fabricated Thumb Impressions

Three boxes of seals—those of Maheshwarnath, the Rani Women's Assistance Committee, and 'म.न.से.'—are discovered alongside a rubber pad for producing artificial thumb impressions. Symbols of institutional authority and of the individual body have been stored in the same secret place. The novel's ethical question centres on the fact that a clean impression is not proof of freely given consent. Gadadhar's statement about taking thumb impressions after applying oil exposes the gap between lived experience and manufactured agreement. But the discovery of rubber material does not show that every impression was forged; comparison is possible only when the original documents are available.

The Column of Fear in the Blue Register

In the chest's blue register, names such as Ramratiya, Somari and Ramsagar appear alongside indications of loneliness, children living away from home, banks, telephones, fear of arrest and the rehearsal of voices. A supposed list for serving beneficiaries becomes a record of techniques for exploiting their fears. The narrator supplies the central incident: personal

relationships themselves can be converted into measurable targets. Meera's intervention—that the private names of victims must not be read aloud—prevents the public inquiry from turning suffering into a second form of trade.

The Layer of the Batuknath Memorial Fund

A folded page mentions the 'Batuknath Hariharan Memorial Fund', together with blank certificates, stamped orders, a voice list and the number of active accounts. The suggestion that the prestige of a deceased founder is being reused within a living documentary network becomes more forceful. Nonetheless, the figures are claims entered in that register, not independent confirmation of all the objects or transactions. The appearance of the names Maheshwar, Dhruvesh and Madhukar on separate short lines gives the investigation a climactic force, but the distinction between a description of roles and criminal liability must not be erased.

The Chest as a Verbal Metaphor and Its Full Legal Name

Aruni imaginatively reads 'L.P.' as 'लूटल चिन्हारि' ('a stolen identity'), while Ananya hears in it 'नुकायल पीड़ा' ('concealed suffering'). Meera, however, insists that the official inventory record the object by its full name, 'लोहाँक पेटी' ('the iron chest'). Here the novel identifies a limit to its own linguistic method. Metaphor expands the reader's field of meaning; an authorised description maintains a consistent identification of the object. These two voices protect the long narrative from becoming a mere proclamation, since literary interpretation and a procedurally valid record have different functions.

The Sealed Chest and the New Questions

By evening the contents of the chest have been numbered and placed under police supervision, and the chest is sealed. It is physically open, but the story is not finished: every column of the blue register awaits its transformation into the next chapter's narrative. By the end, the rusted iron of the title no longer represents fear's permanence; it signifies a change in who keeps watch. The return of Bisesar's incomplete name joins the early bridge disaster to contemporary financial crime in a single resonance. This is not an incidental recollection but the long novel's sustained structural interweaving.

Critical Section 291 | Original Chapter 190 — The Blue Register

The Register's Colour and a New Narrative Language

The blue register recovered from the iron chest becomes almost a principal character in this chapter. Through colour, the narrator brings together different layers of fear, service, discipline and the appropriation of records. The blue imprint was earlier a wound left by a seal; now it becomes the vein running through the entire page. At the centre of this narrative situation lies the contradiction between the heading 'Service List: Special Protection' and the columns recording fear. Its words promise assistance, while its organisation lets the reader see how a victim is measured.

The Human Disintegration of Seven Columns

Columns for name, relationship, fear, voice, account, share and status turn a human being, together with their relationships, into an object. The novel's criticism is not that keeping a register is inherently unjust; it asks for whose benefit the purpose of registration has been transformed. How a list once intended to detail assistance to families became a target list for those trading in terror is the real axis of inquiry. The narrator traces a gradual change in the same object's social meaning, compressing several decades into the space of one page.

Uncertain Accusation Attached to Rani's Name

The blue register includes a reference to a 'Rani' account, women's names, serial numbers of counterfeit thumb impressions, and notes such as 'explained', 'frightened' and 'call again'. Meera makes clear that an account under a woman's name is insufficient grounds for treating her as a suspect. This textual caution continues the ethical argument of the Rani episode in Chapter 187. Communal memory could have fixed the woman's name into a story of her guilt; instead, the narrative teaches readers to examine a method of committing wrongdoing through the use of women's names.

The Folded Map and the Writing of Roles

Inside a fold of the register is a map whose blue lines connect the Harihar Service Centre, Maheshwar's trust, the Rani account, SIM cards, bank branches, a practice room and a room in the city. Beside Madhukar is written 'voice'; beside Dhruvesh, 'instructions'; and beside Maheshwar, 'blessing/seal'. The map rearranges the locations of events into a network. Yet each word may also be a role label supplied by whoever made the

register. Critical reading must notice that the characters attempt to verify those labels rather than accepting them unquestioningly.

The Dramatic Reversal of the 'Practice' Section

The register contains instructions for telephone speech: when to awaken maternal affection in someone's voice, when to threaten arrest and when to pronounce the word 'immediately'. At the earlier Videha Theatre Festival, acting became a public encounter with truth; here acting is the false authority of private fraud. The narrative technique is similar, but its ethical direction has been reversed. Through this internal relationship between performances, the novel conveys the frightening awareness that a human voice can be trained towards radically different ends.

Figures for Shares and the Absence of a Seal

The register's financial section mentions five and twelve per cent, 'special' payments, routes for cash and transfers of service donations. Dhruvesh's initials appear, but Maheshwar's personal seal is not directly present on this page. This balance of presence and absence produces the narrative's restrained mystery. No single page provides the complete picture of the alleged crime; each reveals only part of the operation. Meera also reads the ethical chain—someone created fear, someone moved money through accounts, someone sold trust in the word 'service'—but tracing that chain to a conclusion requires the underlying financial records.

The Shifting Centre of Gadadhar's Character

Gadadhar first appeared as the keeper of the chest's key, an elderly watchman who hesitated to speak. He now says the register originally listed genuine beneficiaries and later, in Dhruvesh's period, became a list of numerical targets. Meera has him distinguish what he witnessed himself from what he heard from others. The form of his moral awakening is therefore unexpected: from a possible observer of wrongdoing, he becomes a witness with a limited evidentiary role. The narrator does not proclaim him a hero; his fear, silence and new testimony remain present on the same page.

The Old River Returns Through Nand Aruni's Name

The blue register lists 'Nand Aruni', with references to an engineer, a report, a workers' list, kinship links and the word 'caution'. Aruni is stunned to see a thread connecting the entry to his father or family memory. Brief signs such as 'diary', 'gamchha' and 'Ba' again evoke the Ganga bridge and its water-burial memories. This return connects the recent cyberfraud to the earlier tragedy within the long novel. Yet the

entry alone does not establish the full circumstances in which Nand's report was taken, nor who was responsible.

The Derogatory Name 'Woman of the Well'

A possible reference to Hulasi appears as 'इनारबाली' ('the woman of the well'). The characters understand it not as a legitimate replacement for her name but as a derogatory abbreviation. Meera proposes correcting it when the real name has been established. The scene shows that names disappear not only through physical death but through administrative classification and social mockery. Memories of the earlier Charmakarni, widows, labourers and nameless people stand behind this single sign. Ananya's role as guardian of names thus acquires a new ethical and procedural meaning.

Foreshadowing the Invisible Chair

A thin sheet falls from the register's cover, carrying the instruction: 'Do not open a page without asking the chair.' In place of a signature are two circles and an oblique stroke. Higher authority thus enters the narrative in the material shape of an empty chair. The office's upper room is still closed, but the back of its chair can be seen through the window. This clear anticipation keeps the next chapter from seeming an unnatural leap. The object substitutes for a person's presence without itself becoming the perpetrator.

Keeping Anger Off the Original Page

Ananya makes separate lists in three colours for victims, witnesses and suspects, while the original pages remain untouched. Her procedure resembles the red, yellow and black threads previously used in Channa Grove, although the meanings assigned to the colours have changed. It would be a mistake to treat them as precisely the same classification. Meera safeguards the distinctions between copy and original, privacy and inference, and between different evidentiary roles. This discipline makes the blue register credible not as a complete verdict on every crime, but as a means of organising questions.

Critical Section 292 | Original Chapter 191 — Dhruvesh's Chair

The Rule of the Empty Chair

The blue register's secret injunction, 'Ask the chair', takes visible form in the next chapter as a chair in the upper room of the Harihar Service Centre. The narrator removes the person from the scene and turns orders issued in his name into a physical seat. Whether the chair is abandoned or was recently in use becomes a question prompted by dust on the wall, worn upholstery, a bell and signs left by a telephone. This narrative absence does more than intensify mystery: it represents the way an institution can generate fear even without an official's direct presence.

The Staircase to the Upper Room

As the group climbs the stairs, the narrator separately records dust on the steps, betel stains, worn marks left by shoes and fallen lime. Each step becomes something like a stratum of time. Poor people wait below, while a forbidden room lies above: vertical space is being transformed into a hierarchy of social power. Bhikhari Lal's ageing body, associated with old keys, and Gadadhar's former task of sweeping place them close to this division. Yet marks on the staircase cannot supply a reliable chronology of which person came and when.

The Narrative Slowness of Making an Inventory

Before the room is opened, Meera establishes rules for recording its dust, objects, wires, drawers, marks and possible footprints. At the climax of a mystery, such measurement checks the reader's impatience. The chapter's narrative tempo arises from the tension between detective suspense and documentary precaution. Ananya and Aruni understand heroism not as breaking down a door but as recording the circumstances in which it was opened. The sequence in which evidence is documented becomes the sequence in which the scene is narrated.

Gadadhar and the Bell of Command

On the chair's desk are a bell, a broken charger and a box containing a seal. Gadadhar explains that whenever the bell rang, he sent tea, water, files or people upstairs. The small metallic sound links service, control and silence: even if the speaker of an order was unseen, its effects continued below. Gadadhar, who describes himself as merely a watchman, now supplies first-hand knowledge of institutional practices. Yet the operation of a bell does not automatically establish Dhruvesh's personal participation in those practices.

The Sentence of Fear in the Drawer

The first drawer contains instructions such as ‘mother alone—soft voice’, together with the final digits of bank accounts. The phrase ‘mother alone’ from the blue register now returns as a slip in a working room. In this way, the narrator constructs a connection between a written plan and its possible practice. An elderly mother’s domestic circumstances are lifted from administrative information and turned into instructions for a performance. Memories of the earlier chapters about digital arrest are compressed into this single sentence on a slip of paper.

A Silent Device and Blank Statement Forms

Vineet Jha does not immediately play the sound-recording device found in the second drawer. In a concealed compartment of the third drawer are blank statement forms marked by a blue dot in one corner. The two objects present a meaningful opposition: one contains a voice that is not yet heard; the other already provides an empty place in which someone’s voice might be written. Such forms may have helped to produce predetermined admissions, although the original narrative does not yet verify their every use. The narrator makes this interior darkness of borrowed or appropriated testimony a powerful image.

The Route Map and the Discipline of Investigation

A wall map resembling a development plan actually joins Garh Narikel, the station, a bank, telephone shops and the Harihar Service Centre. The difference between a map of public service and a map for selecting victims provides one of the chapter’s strongest visual contrasts. The characters count its lines without treating it as a complete account of a crime. Beyond the rear window the upper leaves of Channa Grove are visible, linking the office to the village’s public-hearing scenes. The physical distance is small; the distance separating positions of power is immense.

Nand’s Report Beneath the Chair

Beneath the cushion is an envelope marked ‘ध्रु.’ containing a torn fragment of Nand Aruni’s report: ‘The list of deaths is incomplete. Verification of names is necessary.’ The discovery carries the investigation of present-day digital intimidation back to the suppressed history of the original bridge disaster. Aruni’s trembling registers not merely the thrill of finding a clue but the personal trauma of remembering his father. The abbreviation ‘ध्रु.’ does not conclusively identify Dhruvesh, and it is not known who placed the fragment beneath the chair. The gravity of the narrative rests partly on these limits of knowledge.

Blue Thread and the Local Memory of Soil

A blue thread and dried soil are found near a wheel of the chair. Gadadhar says the earth resembles that of the area around Channa Grove, but similarity of colour does not establish the actual route by which someone travelled. Material substances again carry social memory in the narrative: river mud, an old iron lock and an office chair's wheel seem to converse with one another. In folk belief, the grove looks towards the wrongdoer; within documentary inquiry, the thread becomes a sample that can be examined. The registers of belief and evidence remain distinct.

Prayer Garlands in a Room of Control

Behind the chair lie a dried garland and the ash of incense. Gadadhar recalls an old requirement to offer incense on every new-moon day. These objects evoke the earlier tradition of Batuknath's donation ceremonies. The narrator does not declare the articles of religious observance inherently violent; rather, the scene suggests that devotional decoration may have clothed a room of command in a sacred routine of obedience. The image blurs the boundary between a service institution and the exercise of private control.

The Chair Remains; a Boundary Is Drawn

At dusk the chair is left in place, a yellow line is drawn around it, photographs and inventories are made, and the room is sealed. Rather than carrying off the object at the centre of fear, the investigators identify and guard it. Near Channa Grove it is not the chair itself but the circular outline of its dust that is reproduced; this choice clarifies the relation between an object and the story told about it. The possibility of opening the sealed recorder in the next chapter takes the narrative into a new layer of voices, while Dhruvesh's personal responsibility remains under investigation.

Critical Section 293 | Original Chapter 192 — The Voice of the Switched-Off Recorder

A Story Opening from a Silent Device

The switched-off recorder found in the drawer of Dhruvesh's chair becomes the narrative's new centre in Chapter 192. Against an earlier atmosphere that seemed to carry the sounds of river, grove and pond, a waiting silence gathers around voices that were recorded but have not been heard. The title's paradox is significant: the device is off, yet the voices within it may speak with enormous social force. The narrator creates a pause between the stillness of a material object and a possible auditory explosion. The pause increases detective suspense while raising ethical questions about immediately playing the recording.

Abhay's Arrival and the Limits of Expertise

Abhay, an examiner of audio records, arrives with Vineet Jha. Even his removal of his shoes is not a supernatural event; it serves the practical purpose of keeping dust away from the equipment. Meera recalls the older archival meaning of dust. Scientific procedure and the village's memory of objects appear here not as enemies but as perspectives in dialogue. Abhay first makes a copy of the memory card and preserves the original. This scene establishes a minute rule for protecting truth amid the excitement of a literary mystery.

The Grammar of Fear in File Names

The memory card contains files named 'नरम_माय' ('soft_mother'), 'कानून_डर' ('law_fear'), 'बेटा_बाहर' ('son_away'), 'स्वीकार' ('admit'), 'कुर्सी_राति' ('chair_night'), 'नन्द_सूची' ('Nand_list') and 'नया_पंजी' ('new_register'). These are not merely technical file names; they resemble scene headings in a play written from the documented circumstances of people. What were columns in the blue register now become rehearsals for performances using the voice. The narrator places the passage from written instruction to sound beside a single table, joining the scattered materials of many earlier chapters into a sequence.

The Pretended Compassion of the Soft Mother

In the 'soft_mother' file, a sweet voice promises special assistance from the service centre, while a background whisper gives the direction, 'Not a threat—affection.' The scene exposes a subtle form of psychological violence: fear enters by performing tenderness. The language of the actual relationships among a mother, an older woman and a son living away is

borrowed for a fraudulent script. A second man's voice in the background creates a distinct layer of sound, but the speaker cannot yet be identified with certainty.

The Theft of the Voice of Law

The 'law_fear' file mixes official-sounding Hindi, fractured English and threats of arrest. Satyavrat calls it the theft of the state's language. The episode revives memories of earlier court verandas, adjourned hearings and the long-standing fear experienced by the poor. The narrator shows a similar manner of speaking operating in two settings: the legitimate institutional framework of an actual court and a fraudster's counterfeit stage. Language is not a neutral implement here; its social prestige can imprison the listener who hears it.

Bisesar's Name and the Entry of an Earlier Time

In one segment of the recording, a voice says that 'Bisesar's case is old' and instructs someone not to reopen it. Bisesar Paswan's incomplete name had appeared in the iron chest; now it is present inside a recorded voice as well. This connection brings the water-burial history of the Ganga bridge back as an unavoidable past within the chapters on digital fraud. But the existence of the recording does not show that the person speaking was personally culpable for the original circumstances of Bisesar's death. Narrative connection and criminal responsibility belong to different levels.

The Nand List and the Edited Voice

In the 'Nand_list' file, someone reads aloud fragments of Nand Aruni's torn report—the incomplete list of deaths, safety belts and missing names—and a voice from behind orders portions to be cut. By translating the mutilation of a written report into sound editing, the scene produces a significant self-reflection within the long narrative. The history cut out of the paper is now also threatened with the cutting of its voice. The sentence heard on the recording is not necessarily the authentic text of the original report; it must be compared with the surviving fragments.

The Violent Dialogue of the 'Admit' File

Behind a woman's sobbing, a voice resembling Madhukar's pressures her to say that she handed over the papers voluntarily. The narrative reveals a cruel relation between an imitated voice and 'consent' spoken under compulsion. In the earlier chapters, the conversion of silence or a false statement into a consent document was a written problem; now it becomes a recorded exchange. Gadadhar thinks he recognises Madhukar's voice,

but Abhay and Vineet insist that legal identification requires comparison of the source, voice samples and recording time.

The Wordless Sounds of 'Chair Night'

The file 'chair_night' contains the scrape of a chair, the hum of a fan, a phone's vibration, the sounds of paper and breathing. An absence of clear speech does not make the narrative empty; it introduces the physical substance of sound. From a whisper emerges something like 'separate the new names', which may correspond to a final instruction in the blue register. Hearing cannot simply be declared more accurate than seeing. The limits of listening, together with the recorder's crackle, create a double uncertainty.

The Threat Reaches the Children

The 'new_register' file contains talk of removing names, discrediting those who speak and keeping watch on the children. The public work of Ananya and Aruni, guardians of names, now becomes a matter of their personal safety. Meera distinguishes courage from recklessness. The scene positions the child characters not merely as moral exemplars but as vulnerable bodies in a dangerous world. Rather than glorifying fearlessness, the narrator stresses the need for collective protection and secure copies of the evidence.

The Empty Bowl and the Voice's Undecided Face

The recorder is preserved together with the original device; at Channa Grove that day, an empty earthen bowl is placed in its stead. The bowl is a metaphorical place for the voice, which has no material shape of its own but can produce consequences for human bodies. The chapter does not end with a definitive identification of Madhukar, Dhruvesh or the possible background speaker. The image of the empty bowl gives form to that incompletion. Searching for voice samples and a face in the following chapter thus becomes a natural narrative necessity.

Critical Section 294 | Original Chapter 193 — The Face of the Voice

The Ear's Trust and the Mirror of Law

Following "The Voice of the Switched-Off Recorder," the title "The Face of the Voice" constructs a metaphorical impossibility: it seeks a visible identity for something heard. This desire drives the detective plot. At the outset, Meera cautions that no one can be found guilty merely because a voice sounds familiar. Time, place, equipment, samples and witnesses must be brought together. The narrative thus creates tension between the community's impulse towards instant recognition and the slow temporality of investigation. For the present, the face remains a symbol, not an identification established by law.

Madhukar's Five Controlled Sentences

Madhukar is given water in a separate room and asked to read five sentences. His voice falters over formulations such as "Do not disconnect the phone" and "Say only what you are told to say." The narrator turns an uncomfortable bodily response into a legible sign, but nervousness is not, in itself, judicial proof of guilt. Meera asks him to finish reading. The accused character is no longer presented merely as an image of absolute darkness: he becomes a human being who experiences pressure and must answer questions.

Recovering Dhruvesh's Public Address

An old disc at the service centre yields a devotional song followed by footage of an inauguration. On the platform Dhruvesh describes the sufferings of the poor as his own. The narrator first evokes the memory of public applause, then places that public statement beside the instructions on the switched-off recorder. The same person's image and voice acquire different meanings on different stages. The language of service at an inauguration does not prove its own falsity: it must be examined alongside the audio instructions proposing the sequence "first trust, then fear."

Small Marks of Pronunciation

Ananya records a clearing of the throat before "r," a whistling "s," pauses for breath and the release at the end of sentences. Such fine detail balances the great metaphors of water, leaves and ghosts with the realism of minute audible features. Abhay's sound trace and the child's ear are not opposing authorities; they provide different sources for comparison. Yet the novel itself acknowledges that voices can also be altered through practice.

Acoustic resemblance is therefore a possible argument, not complete identification.

The Return of "First Trust, Then Fear"

The phrase "first trust" recurs in the instructions attributed to Madhukar on the recorder and in Dhruvesh's public address. The narrator places the same wording within two ethical worlds: service on a platform and the commercial use of fear inside a locked room. This intertextual repetition gives the sprawling narrative a central audible motif. The reader comes to understand that the perpetrators do not invent an entirely new language; they rearrange an already accepted vocabulary of service into a business sustained by fear.

Madhukar's Written Statement and Its Limits

Madhukar states that several instructions came over Dhruvesh's telephone, that notes sometimes arrived through Maheshwar, and that an unfamiliar voice could be heard in the background. This chain advances the investigation, but Madhukar is himself a potentially implicated person; his testimony cannot simply be taken as an impartial account of history. Meera does not take hold of his hand to obtain a signature. The act of consenting must remain his own. The present scene thereby offers an ethical answer to the forced consent manufactured in the past.

The Unfinished Language of the Expert Report

Abhay finds the audio characteristics of segments from the recorder, the inauguration address, the bank meeting and Madhukar's sample suitable for comparison, but reserves a final scientific opinion for an expert laboratory. The qualification introduces restraint at a dramatic high point. Community witnesses want the face to be revealed immediately; the technical examiner insists that resemblance is not conclusive. Rather than suppressing the disagreement, the narrative makes it a reason to continue the inquiry.

A Small Lamp in Place of a Name

Instead of publicly recording the name of a frightened elderly woman, Ananya draws a small lamp on the page. This act of protecting a name significantly modifies the long-running motif of the "guardians of names": safeguarding a name does not always mean reading it aloud. At times, withholding a name protects its bearer's dignity. Excessive publicity can itself become another form of humiliation. By making this ethical choice between public memory and confidentiality, the novel prevents its collective voice from collapsing into the single voice of a crowd.

The Black Mark on Dhruvesh's Photograph

An old photograph of Dhruvesh hangs on the service centre wall. A black mark near his shoulder looks to Ananya like a leaf from Channa Grove, while Abhay requests a separate visual examination to establish what it signifies. Here a magical-realist way of seeing settles upon a photograph, yet the limits of photographic evidence remain acknowledged. The presence of the grove is a philosophical image within the reader's experience; technical interpretation of the preserved photograph must proceed on a different level.

The Voices of Folk Ghosts and the Stolen Voice

The old ghost connects missing names with stolen voices. Black and white apparitions, the half-face of the water-dweller, and the folk sounds of Channa Grove constitute another narrative plane. These folk presences are not judicial witnesses to the inquiry but emotional echoes of social injury. The novel places the theft of a voice simultaneously in a technological folder and within the remembered world of village ghosts. Through this coexistence, magical realism becomes not a replacement for evidence but an enlargement of what suffering means.

The Incomplete Face and the Foreshadowing of a Summons

At the chapter's close, the sense remains that "the face did not become fully visible," although "the doorway of breath was found." On the next page Ananya writes an indication that a summons should be sent to the face. Even after comparing voices, hearing Madhukar's statement and discovering the old disc, the narrator declares no decisive victory. The narrative turns towards a formal process of seeking an answer. This suspension embodies its ethical argument: progress in an investigation may require an accused person's appearance without already declaring that person guilty.

Critical Section 295 | Original Chapter 194 — The Summons of Breath

The Reversed Direction of the Word "Summons"

In an earlier sequence set on the court veranda, a "summons" had embodied terrible fear for poor litigants. Chapter 194 reverses the direction of the word: this time it is not a victim but the possible shadow of someone who gave orders that is being called. Meera clarifies that a summons is not punishment; it is a procedure requiring a response. The same institutional term changes meaning as the social position of the person addressed changes. That semantic reversal is the chapter's narratological centre: a formal legal notice also becomes the sign of a social reversal.

Abhay's Qualified Finding of Acoustic Resemblance

After comparing the audio record, Dhruvesh's inauguration speech and Madhukar's sample, Abhay notes similarities but asks for a legally obtained, controlled voice sample. The villagers hear "sufficient" and immediately expect an arrest; they hear "not conclusive" and are disappointed. The narrator places the rapid motion of public desire alongside the slower procedure of scientific measurement. Because of this divergence, the novel does not become a simple story in which evidence achieves instant victory.

The Gleam of Service at the Gate

Dhruvesh's house is furnished with a high gate, cameras, tiles and a fountain, alongside a smiling advertisement promising service to the poor. This material setting displays economic power in contrast with the dusty houses of those who have suffered. When the summons is affixed beneath the advertisement, the image of public benevolence and the written demand for personal accountability occupy one frame. The visual irony is sharp: the smile on the poster makes the absence of a response still more legible.

Sheetanshu's Gentle Resistance

The guard and Sheetanshu respond to the request that they accept the summons with phrases such as "Babu is away," "I have no information," and "I am not refusing." The narrator locates resistance not in open threats but in courteous administrative evasion. Recorded time, witnesses, photographs and the order in which the notice is affixed become narrative resistance to this gentle refusal. The paper is placed on the gate, but the

text does not proclaim that Dhruvesh received it in person. Maintaining that distinction matters for criticism as well.

Affixing a Summons versus Receiving It

Aruni specifically records that a claim that the summons "was served" and the observable event of its having "been seen" are different things. Its affixing to the gate, the telephone ringing inside and the manager's monitoring of events are three independent details. Through a child's perspective, the author exposes a small but decisive difference in legal narration. The guardian of names now learns to record not merely correct spellings but accurate verb tenses and the real extent to which an action was completed.

The Many Stories of the Absent Dhruvesh

Contradictory voices in the village suggest that Dhruvesh has fled, is ill, or has become the victim of a conspiracy. Meera insists that the source of each assertion be established. The scene reveals that even within an omniscient narrative community members produce numerous incomplete stories. Criticism must not confuse the existence of a rumour with the existence of the fact it alleges. The accused man's absence helps to construct mystery, but is not in itself proof of either flight or wrongdoing.

Controlled Sentences and a Character's Rights

Sentences such as "Service is not a trade in fear" and "Build trust first" are selected for a possible legally controlled voice sample from Dhruvesh. The rhetoric of an ordinary public speech and phrases belonging to a script of intimidation enter the same testing environment. The chapter asks whether a voice can be isolated from performance: when the language of wrongdoing is itself rehearsed, how is an authentic voice to be recognised? The narrator describes a proposed test, not a test already administered or a result obtained.

The Summary of the Summons and the Community's Impatience

Copies of the personal summons are not distributed among the assembled people; only its substance is read aloud. Meera maintains a boundary between public accountability and the confidentiality of individual legal procedure. The accused has been called to respond, not proved guilty. The community's invisible court thus does not replace legal justice: through social memory it questions and supports that process. The public wants revenge; the narrative asks it to work instead with documented evidence.

The Bank's Pulse and the Breath of the Voice

Vineet Jha sends the bank information about monitoring suspicious accounts and unusually large withdrawals. At this point the symbol of "breath" is joined to the "pulse" of money. The numerical voice of wrongdoing does not circulate freely through the air; it is sustained by networks of transactions. The narrative brings the language of the physical body, technological signals and financial accounts into a single rhythm. Yet notification about monitoring and the actual freezing of an account are different events. The following chapter will turn that difference into an outcome.

A Folk Summons to the Dead

Near Channa Grove the names of Bisesar Paswan, Nand Aruni, Chhotu and an unnamed frightened woman are called; after each name the air is left empty. This is not a judicial summons but a folk-theatrical figure of remembrance. Falling leaves, a barking dog and ripples on the pond are not declared to be direct responses from the dead: they render a social void perceptible to the senses. This polyphonic scene bridges the earlier water burial and the present summons.

Mohan Paswan's Limited Admission

Mohan Paswan, a former assistant to Sheetanshu, says that he delivered two sealed envelopes: one to Dhruvesh's home and the other to a lane behind the bank. He did not see what they contained. His statement opens a possible route along which the envelopes moved, but leaves the meaning of their contents unknown. An instruction such as "no receipt, no memory" dramatises institutional forgetting. It foreshadows the following chapter's frozen accounts without itself establishing anyone's ultimate financial liability.

Critical Section 296 | Original Chapter 195 — The Frozen Account

The Morning Queue and the Double Meaning of a Freeze

The chapter opens with news that accounts are to be frozen. As soon as the bank shutter is lifted halfway, however, a queue of pensioners, labourers, students and frightened women becomes visible outside. The reader immediately recognises that stopping the circulation of financial wrongdoing may also touch the immediate needs of affected families. The narrator presents a "freeze" not simply as a punitive triumph but as a decision with the potential to inflict unintended social harm. This scene makes the novel's ethical meaning more finely differentiated.

The Discipline of Reconciling Multiple Sources

Vineet Jha orders that no account be frozen merely because two names resemble one another; the source of funds, their movement, beneficiaries, signatures and telephone links must all be checked. Manoj Mishra's everyday documentary world as bank manager and the folk register kept at Channa Grove now appear on the same plane. The narrator attaches a renewed demand for proof to every blocking order. The blue register, once a possible instrument of wrongdoing, now becomes, through its copies, a source of questions in the effort to prevent further wrongdoing.

The Brightly Worded Title of the Service Fund

The stated aims of the "Harihar Service Centre Assistance Fund" are care of the elderly, scholarships and disaster relief. Yet the accounts show small deposits followed by large withdrawals on a single day, together with vague expenditure under "special service." The contrast between words and transactions transfers the novel's earlier motif of the "debt of charity" into a financial narrative. Meera asks: special service for whom? Her question demands not merely an explanation of figures but an ethical account of whom this promise of assistance actually addressed.

The Circular Movement Through Madhukar-Linked Accounts

Accounts held in the names of Madhukar's relatives show small amounts moving in and out repeatedly. The description of money leaving an elderly person's account, passing through intermediary accounts and becoming cash maps a possible course of wrongdoing. The financial benefit that might have accrued to the makers of fraudulent voices becomes a question raised by the scene. But treating every family member as culpable merely because an account bears a family name would violate the caution of the

original text. Printed bank slips and actual beneficiaries require separate verification.

Surajmukhi Devi's Full Name

The register identifies her as "Surja Devi," but the woman herself gives her full name as "Surajmukhi." The narrator treats this shortening of a name as a diminution of a human being in the bank's numerical world. Ananya writes the full name as Surajmukhi recounts a fabricated threat that her son would be sent to prison. This small correction of address restores a victim's right to speak in her own voice amid an enormous financial inquiry. The protection of names is once again a central narrative action.

Five Accounts Frozen, the Others Under Investigation

The chapter distinguishes five accounts on which restrictions have been imposed, two accounts subject to partial inquiry, three being monitored, and a disputed account belonging to Dhruvesh's private research trust. Reducing these different states to a conclusion that "all the accounts were seized" would be inaccurate. The narrative shows interim results in the middle of a financial investigation, not final recovery of funds. This precision gives the long narrative a credible structure of time: decisions develop through several distinct stages rather than in one straight line.

The Many Telephone Voices After the Freeze

As news of the frozen accounts spreads, different voices intervene: warnings that service will be interrupted, objections framed in defence of a charitable fund, Madhukar's trembling request, and unidentified threats directed at the children. The narrator connects earlier episodes of rehearsed voices with the financial consequences now emerging. Once the passage of money is restricted, the tone of public language changes. Yet the identity of callers and the chain of instructions behind them still demand independent confirmation; this plurality of voices does not resolve itself into a single conclusively identified perpetrator.

Manoj Mishra's Statement and the Word "Above"

The bank manager, Manoj Mishra, acknowledges that during earlier large withdrawals telephone calls arrived "from above." The word "above," previously examined in connection with the chair room, the seal-bearer's orders and court documents, now surfaces inside the bank. Its recurrence satirises the language of political and institutional hierarchy. Nevertheless, even where "Dhruvesh's instruction" is a commonly repeated description, it is not the manager's complete direct proof. Satyavrat records that distinction as something still requiring investigation.

A Payment in the Name of Nand's Report

A cash-withdrawal slip bears the description "Nand Aruni Report Assistance." The inquiry into present accounts abruptly descends into the old Ganga bridge disaster, Nand's incomplete report and Aruni's inherited memories. The trembling of Aruni's hand is among the narrative's deepest personal moments. The connection between money and the memory of the dead has been disclosed, but who received the payment and how the report was used remain uncertain. The return of a name is narrative justice; financial justice is still unfinished.

Recovered Money versus Restitution to Victims

The assembled people ask how much of the frozen money will come back. Meera makes clear that restricting an account and recovering money for return to the victims are separate legal stages. Surajmukhi asks when she will receive her funds, but Meera refuses to sell her an invented date. The voice of the narrative is emotionally honest: the public hearing at Channa Grove does not promise a miraculous outcome without a process to achieve it. Meera decides that the accounts under investigation and the separate register of victims' claims must remain distinct. The financial drama is not allowed to overwhelm human hope.

The Changing Meaning of Water Burial

During the final night the crocodile, the water-dweller, the old ghost and Hulasi form a circle of remembrance around the names. "Water burial" is no longer only the sinking of a body beneath water; it becomes a metaphor for names submerged in forgetfulness. Bisesar's bridge disaster, Nand's report, Surajmukhi's money and an elderly woman's stolen voice are different forms of a wider dispossession. But the real difference between physical death and financial loss must be preserved. Their symbolic resemblance does not entitle the reader to treat these sufferings as identical events.

The Shadow of the Final Account and the Next Turn towards Water

Two further accounts belonging to Dhruvesh's research trust, the ironic stated aim of "folk-memory preservation," and an unanswered telephone call to a machine carry the mystery into the next part. One financial channel has been obstructed, but another may have been used to market the erasure of names. Ananya opens her notebook and writes "The Meaning of Water Burial." This ending does not declare final victory; it is a structural bridge turning the narrative back towards its initial disaster in the water. After eight chapters, the novel returns to an old wound carrying new evidence.

Inter-Sectional Analysis: From Maheshwar's Seal to the Frozen Account

The sequence of original Chapters 188–195 forms a distinctive narratological circuit. It begins with the blue impression of "Maheshwar's seal" on three papers. The iron chest is then opened; the blue register discloses a classification of names; Dhruvesh's chair becomes the location of an order given in its owner's absence; the voice of the switched-off recorder is heard; comparisons of sound give rise to the question of the face; a summons calls for a response; and, finally, interim restrictions are placed on the movement of funds. This progression passes through changing media—document, object, image, voice, legal language and financial records. The insufficiency of one medium impels the search for the next.

The recurrence of the word "service" in the first three chapters is a constructive irony of the narrative. Rani Women's Assistance Committee, Harihar Service Centre, the memory fund, the register of beneficiaries and special protection all present themselves as signs of public benevolence. Yet beneath these names lie blank letterheads, possible absence of consent, forged thumb impressions and lists of people to be frightened. Nevertheless, before assigning institutional guilt, the novel insists upon separate examination of the production, date, use and source of every seal and page. Thus the narrative may be animated by moral outrage without becoming a simplistic catalogue of accusations.

The earlier bridge disaster becomes vividly present again. In the iron chest Bisesar Paswan's incomplete claim appears under "absence"; in the blue register are Nand Aruni's name and a list of workers; beneath the cushion of Dhruvesh's chair lies a torn report by Nand; on the recorder are instructions not to reopen Bisesar's case and to remove names from Nand's list; and among the frozen accounts appears a payment designated as assistance for Nand's report. The objects change, but incomplete counting of deaths and the removal of names remain central. Rather than mechanical repetition, these returns create the temporal unity of an extended narrative: the original disaster becomes legible again within newer forms of financial wrongdoing.

The organisation of sound is particularly memorable. The chair bell, the creaking fan, the feigned tenderness in "soft_mother," official-sounding threats in "law_fear," the reading of "Nand_list," the scraping sounds of "chair_night," and the repetition of "first trust, then fear" together form the audible architecture of a performance of wrongdoing. But the experts Abhay and Vineet repeatedly maintain that acoustic resemblance is not

conclusive identification: laboratory examination, a legally obtained sample, verified timing, witnesses and preservation of the objects remain necessary. These constraints do not weaken dramatic suspense; they lend it credibility.

The people's ears continually come into conflict with the institutions' registers. Bajrang, an elderly craftsman, recognises marks left in the cutting of a seal; Narhari remembers old forms of names; Gadadhar relates his silent experience of keys and bells; Aruni trembles through memories of his father; Ananya records small verbal details and names; Somari, Surajmukhi and other women speak about the pressures exerted on them; Abhay and Vineet explain the limits of equipment; and Meera protects the personal boundaries of statements. This polycentric structure of knowledge does not install an all-knowing judge above everyone. The story's truth is constructed gradually from several incomplete positions.

A specific caution about names is necessary. An earlier school register identified Maheshwar Mishra as the father of Madhukar Madhav Mishra, whereas the present sequence introduces "Maheshwarnath Sevak," "Mahesar," "M. N. Sevak," and a key-keeper associated with an institution. The passages discussed do not finally establish that all these designations refer to one person. Likewise, the use of Dhruvesh's chair, the abbreviation "Dhru.," resemblance between voices and blank orders represent separate levels of inference based on their sources. These uncertainties deserve analysis, including the possibility of literary inconsistency; without corroboration they must not be turned into a fully proven history of crime.

The effect of magical realism is distributed across visible signs and responses of nature. The shadow of a blue seal falls on the leaves of the grove; a rusted key seems to breathe; ghosts gather near a half-visible impression; an empty earthen bowl becomes the shape of a voice; Bisesar's old water burial echoes in bank accounts; and the water-dweller places a drop of dew on a page. These folk images give emotional grammar to financial, documentary and acoustic violence, but they do not replace actual examination of the origin of a seal, a sound recording or a bank transaction.

Critical Section 296, "The Frozen Account," is the dramatic culmination of these eight chapters, but its outcome is provisional. The actual restriction of five accounts, investigation of two, monitoring of three, a disputed financial channel associated with the trust, and a separate register of victims' claims are distinct stages. Meera gives Surajmukhi no invented date for the return of her money; legal proceedings, identification of actual beneficiaries and restitution remain ahead. Here the novel extends water burial from the sinking of bodies to the submergence of names in

oblivion. Consequently, its movement into the final five chapters is not merely the closing of a criminal network, but the attempt to recover an unfinished memory.

Critical Section 297 | Original Chapter 196 — The Meaning of Water Burial

The Final Rereading of the Title and the Transformation of Meaning

Chapter 196 opens by questioning the novel's title anew. "Water burial" had initially evoked the river, crocodiles, a splash and the fear of bodies disappearing. Here Meera reads it alongside the erasure of names, falsified records, the suppression of women's voices, dispossession of land and digital fraud. This does not mean that actual deaths by drowning dissolve into symbols. On the contrary, those deaths become the measure against which the narrative recognises its other forms of injury. Extending the meaning of the title is the principal action of the novel's approaching conclusion: it answers an initial question without allowing the answer to become one-dimensional.

The Bowl of Three Waters: A Small Figure of the Plot

Aruni's empty water vessel and the bronze bowl carried by Fakira Sahani's son stand at the chapter's centre. The well, the Kamla-Balan and the Ganga belong to different geographical scenes, but drops from all three waters in one vessel bring buried domestic deaths, land eroded by a river and the absence of bridge workers into a single contact of memories. Here the narrator compresses an immense narrative into a small object. The bowl is not a summary of the story but the material presence of relations among places; each drop of water is therefore accompanied by the utterance of a different history.

Fakira Sahani's Son: The Entry of Generational Witness

Fakira Sahani's son has himself grown old. This fine detail makes the time elapsed since the original catastrophe more than a date: it is inscribed upon a living body. A father's testimony is voiced again through the bowl held by his son. The earlier witness may be absent, but an object carrying his testimony remains present. Narrative authority here is created not by an omniscient command but by the transmission of remembrance between generations. The boatman's descendants carry, in village memory, not only the work of boats but also a duty to call the missing by name.

Nand Aruni's Diary and the Returning Foundational Sentence

Satyavrat Mehta holds a copy of Nand Aruni's diary, from which the foundational line returns: "The crocodile devours the body, not the name." The narrator does not repeat the earlier disaster as if it were a new event; the scene is a rereading of a written page. This recurrence links the chapters devoted to memory. Yet it matters that Satyavrat possesses a copy,

not the original diary: the document's authenticity is still mediated. Even at its close, the work does not make a simple claim of unmediated encounter, but shows the route by which written testimony reaches us.

From "Splash" to "Frozen Account": A Circle of Time

Aruni writes "splash" at one end of a stone, "frozen account" at the other, and "names" between them. Through this scene the long novel draws a map of its own chronology. The sound of the first disaster and the recent restriction of bank accounts seem far apart, yet they are joined by processes that erase names. This is not a circular narration that returns to its beginning unchanged. Each return adds a new document, a new voice and a new relation. The qualitative changes within the narrative sequence become visible in a simple line drawn on stone.

The Second Line, the Woman's Voice, and Domestic Water Burial

At first the image of water burial might have seemed largely centred upon the deaths of male labourers. Writing "a woman's voice" along a second line, from "shame" to "testimony," Meera reminds the reader that water burials were also taking place inside homes. Weeping suppressed beneath a sari's end, papers of refuge, a widow's thumb impression and fear of dishonour underpin this reinterpretation. Through her intervention, the final collective scene does not remain exclusively a memorial to male workers: the novel's perspective on women has an active role in determining the meaning of its ending.

The Third Line of Sound and Breath: The Modern Crocodile's Body

Devika writes "breath" between "voice" and "face." The symbolic distance between the crocodile in the river and threats delivered by telephone, considerable at the beginning, contracts on the stone. The language of false officials, forged orders and stolen family voices violates relationships organised around names. Crucially, the chapter does not proclaim technology itself to be a monster; its concern remains the criminals' use of words and the isolation of victims. In this manner the crocodile's altered incarnation extends from the world of water into the digital world, without forgetting the original disaster.

Reading Verified Names Aloud and Refusing a Spectacle

The names of Bisesar Paswan, Salamat Ansari and others are read beside the bowl. But Meera stops demands for an immediate verdict against Dhruvesh. That restraint is the ethical narrative technique of the chapter: restoring the names of the dead, determining an accused person's guilt, and sharing a community's grief are three separate actions. At the emotional height of public remembrance, the story does not manufacture

a legal conclusion. This discipline prevents a scene resembling a final rite from turning into revenge or a political victory chant, preserving the dignity of mourning itself.

The Circle of Ghosts and the Uncertainty of Those Who See

The black ghost, white apparition and old ghost seem to gather around the bowl and in the shade of the grove. They are not turned into literal witnesses who can replace documents; they give visible form to memory, guilt and protection. Water suddenly appearing bright, or leaves moving, intensifies the magical realism of the fictional world one final time. Yet the registers maintained by Meera and the children continue to distinguish concrete objects, permissions, dates, times and names. The coexistence of imagination and archival record, not the triumph of either over the other, distinguishes this narrative.

Legal Definition and Communal Meaning on Different Planes

Within the novel, Vineet Jha supplies an extended written meaning of "water burial" encompassing death, memory, identity, economic autonomy and the organised suppression of voices. This is a character's formulation inside a work of fiction, not a universally binding legal definition. Its narrative task is to give the community a language for its experience; any actual prosecution would rest on distinct evidence. The novel itself recognises this boundary when Meera separates the families' mourning from Dhruvesh's criminal hearing. The meeting point—and difference—between the communication of ideas in narrative and institutional decisions is clear.

The Proposal of "Water-Unveiling" and the Reversal of Language

At dusk the muddy water in the bowl appears bright, giving rise to the new term "water-unveiling" (*jal-udghatan*). This journey of words from water burial to water-unveiling embodies an emotional transformation in the narrative as a whole. It is not a claim of miraculous resurrection. It expresses faith that the names of those whose bodies can never return may be spoken again. Copies of names and the permission of families ground the metaphor in material practice. The verbal reversal is therefore not merely poetic ornament but a compact commitment to a communal process of remembering.

A Quiet Ending, a New Title, and a Conclusion That Opens Gradually

At the chapter's close, nobody calls for an arrest or announces a plan for victory. Ananya says that the story has returned to its beginning; Satyavrat understands the task as bringing that beginning towards justice. The difference between those two statements holds the temporal vision of the

final part: an event remains in the past yet gains meaning in the present. The bowl is left by the roots of the grove, and a fresh page opens bearing the title “The Names That Rose.” Rather than place a full stop, the narrator adopts a new sequence moving from one question to the next. The first chapter of the concluding movement ends by defining what must still be done.

Critical Section 298 | Original Chapter 197 — The Names That Rose

A Shift in Focalisation from Still Water to an Unsettled Shore

At the beginning of Chapter 197 the water in the bowl is still; yet, as the names rise, the memories and social positions of the people along its shore begin to change. Instead of producing a dramatic whirlpool in the water, the narrator directs focalisation towards the village's response. To "rise" does not mean that bodies return to life; it means that their presence is restored in the records. The opening therefore sets physical calm against inner upheaval. For an assessment of the ending, the distinction is decisive: the true object of the story is the social fate of names that have disappeared, not merely the outward movement of water.

Permission Before Reading: The Ethical Framework of the Hearing of Memory

Meera announces that names will be read publicly only with the families' permission, and that a family choosing silence will retain that right. The narrative recognises the danger of turning grief into an object for a crowd's inspection. Here the narrator deliberately limits the possibilities of the emotional scene: not every tear is available to spectators. Such narrative restraint recalls the novel's earlier theatrical sections, where the question was how a "spectator" might become a "witness." At this assembly for reading names, the family's authority takes precedence over the listener's entitlement.

Wet Leaves and the Fragmentation of Letters

Dew falls on the leaves placed beside the bowl. Some letters grow dark, others fade, while still others break into fragments. In one place only "Chho" remains, and elsewhere "tu." This ordinary physical detail simultaneously reveals the fragility of the object and the instability of memory. Within the story, recovering a name does not occur through an instantly complete inscription; it requires labour that joins broken letters to a family's experience. Ananya's pencil and Satyavrat's old bridge register make that incompleteness a practical problem to be resolved, not simply a melancholy simile.

Phoolkali's Testimony and the First Reconstruction of Chhotu's Name

Phoolkali steps forward and identifies her lost son between the bridge workers' register and her own memory. The text records the name

"Shivlal, alias Chhotu," while distinguishing the documentary categories "dead/missing" and "absent." The scene's central force is not a complete biography of the deceased worker, but the legitimacy of a name pronounced by his mother. In the village's former administrative language, "absent" had served as a convenience; here the same word strikes against the fabric of motherhood. The reading of names exposes a language of falsehood whose consistent documentary correction has yet to be achieved.

A Mother's Memory versus Printed Absence

Satyavrat presents a copy of the old bridge-construction record, but Phoolkali's body and voice take their place as witnesses beside the paper. The narrative perspective shifts from the administrative centre to the threshold of a home. What had been the dreary designation "absent," or an unclear labour status, becomes in the mother's telling a historical disappearance from life. Through this reversal the reader understands that the novel does not oppose evidence; it opposes the exclusion of voices from the making of evidence. The document and remembered experience are not substitutes for one another, but necessary components of a difficult reconciliation.

Different Fathers' Names and Inequality among the Records

Although Bisesar Paswan's name has already been recovered, his father's name differs between two registers. The episode demonstrates that finding one name does not end verification. By introducing so fine an archival difficulty, the narrator interrupts the emotional momentum of the ending. The family's statement and the documentary discrepancy are entered separately, as though even the final public reading of names remains open to correction. This technique draws the reader away from the myth of effortless reunion: the restoration of memory becomes an enduring responsibility to revise the record.

Surajmukhi Devi: The Recovery of Names Is Not Restricted to the Dead

Surajmukhi demands that her name, too, be raised, although her story concerns not death but disgrace in an account and accusations of theft. Her intervention extends the meaning of a "submerged name" to social death. A living person may also disappear within another person's account, a forged signature or a rumour. The narrator links the commemoration of the dead to financial assassination of character without declaring the two experiences identical. The strength of the comparison lies not in asserting sameness but in revealing the mutual dependence of a public name and private identity.

The Plate of Verified Names and the Basket of Names Awaiting Verification

Aruni sets aside a plate for leaves bearing verified names and a separate bamboo basket for names that remain unverified. Devika ties red thread around the basket. These two objects embody the story's investigative method with exceptional concreteness. The plate is not an instrument of irrevocable proclamation; it is a provisional account of names verified through present inquiry. The waiting basket prevents incomplete evidence from being thrown away as rubbish. The narrative acknowledges that every question cannot be answered on the same day. Preserving uncertainty systematically becomes a dramatic expression of the novel's understanding of justice.

The Glimmer of Water and the Temptation to Record a Miracle

After the names are read, drops, faint light and momentary ripples appear on the bowl's surface. Aruni is tempted to write that a miracle has occurred, but the responsibility of making a record checks this temptation. The episode resembles magical realism examining its own procedures. In popular perception, the water may answer for the dead; in a public register, however, what has happened is, for now, an observed occurrence. Restraint within the act of recording does not disown the imagination. It protects imagination from being misrepresented as a documentary fact.

Movement at Dhruvesh's House and the Limits of Narrative Knowledge

During the reading of names, news arrives that there is agitation at Dhruvesh's house, that a lawyer objects to the public hearing, and that a shadow has been seen rushing past an upper window. Some say papers are being tied into bundles; others say telephones are being changed. The narrator does not convert these second-hand possibilities into settled facts. Abhay instructs the others to watch from a distance rather than give chase. The civic recovery of names and an accused man's possible flight proceed simultaneously, while the narrative preserves the tension of incomplete information instead of choosing noise and certainty.

The Genuine Textual Contradiction between Shivlal and Shivnath

In this chapter Phoolkali's son is entered in the register as "Shivlal, alias Chhotu." Yet Chapter 199, "The Dawn Inside the Chest," uses an old wage sheet to declare "Shivnath Sada" to be Chhotu's verified real name. The original narrative provides no clear intervening explanation of whether these are alternative names for one character, a history of renaming, or signs of two different people. A close reading of the last five chapters

therefore encounters a genuine inconsistency of names. Automatically treating it as coherent symbolism would be unjust to the source text.

The Next Ethical Question after the Names Have Risen

At the close of the chapter, verified names, names awaiting verification, earth, the bowl and the shadowed house occupy a single field of vision. Phoolkali's appeal, "Let the name stand on the earth," turns the aquatic metaphor of the title towards land. This prepares the next section, "The Criminal's Earth." A recovered name must now become more than a spoken word; it must press a claim to rights in the material world. The narrative technique converts one chapter's emotional climax into the next chapter's gathering of evidence, keeping the ending in continuous motion.

Critical Section 299 | Original Chapter 198 — The Criminal's Earth

Evidence on the Earthen Track and the Change of Setting

Dhruvesh's car takes the dirt track through the rear gate and its wheels become trapped in wet earth near the threshing ground. The decisive setting is no longer a courthouse veranda or a bank but a long strip of damp soil. This is both an environmental contingency and a recurrence of the novel's practice of "reading the earth." Mud preserves marks that an asphalt road could allow to vanish. The narrator refuses to leave setting as lifeless background. Nevertheless, the social meaning of traces found on the ground emerges from the careful records of those present, not from any miraculous act of automatic justice.

The Iron Chest in Motion and the Excitement of the Scene

In earlier chapters the desired object was the chest's contents; here an attempt to carry the chest away becomes the event itself. The stuck vehicle, three people trying to unload the chest, Dhruvesh's haste and the sound of the engine at night quicken the pace. Yet the passage does not stop with excitement: identifying the object, recording the vehicle's number, and entering the time and location interrupt the thrill. Consequently, the novel does more than gratify a reader with the thought that someone has been "caught." It depicts the narrative labour required to make an event fit for public testimony.

Abhay's Call and the Return of Institutional Delay

Abhay telephones the night-duty team, whose first response is evasive: the matter can be examined "in the morning." An old pattern of judicial delay thus returns on the final night of the catastrophe's long aftermath. The difference is that the villagers now preserve the scene and ask questions. Eventually two employees from the outpost arrive. This sequence defeats the simple designation of the institution as either complete villain or instantaneous rescuer. It is shown moving among indifference, caution and cooperation.

The Children's Distance and the Discipline of Focalisation

From a distance Ananya notes the chest, the number of people and the hour of night; Aruni measures the tyre tracks. Abhay establishes the rule, "Write only as much as you have seen." This sentence makes an important transformation in narrative perspective explicit. Earlier, the children had listened with wonder to crocodiles, ghosts, water and human suffering; now they practise accepting the limits of what their own eyes can verify.

Narrative authority emerges here not from age or position but from the ability to distinguish what was observed from what has merely been said.

The Veil of Prestige Falling Away from Dhruvesh's Body

Standing by the stranded vehicle, Dhruvesh no longer appears as the polished figure on the stage of the service organisation but as a hurried, trapped human being. His missing shawl, the metallic sound of the chest and a shoe stuck in mud visually strip away his social persona. The narrator does not pronounce him definitively guilty before a court has done so. The shoe and bare foot certainly form a literary irony, but Meera restrains the crowd's mockery. Refusing the humiliation of a person even while discussing crime is a central ethical tension of this section.

Surajmukhi Devi's Presence: Watching Over a Stained Name

Surajmukhi does not demand the festive opening of the chest. She wants to make sure that, if it contains papers used to defame her, the box does not disappear before everyone's eyes. Her words reveal the insecurity of memory more than a thirst for revenge. This brief appearance shows that stealing an archive does not merely remove objects; it threatens to steal a person's identity again. Her perspective turns the scene of interception into a question of rights: whom has this evidence harmed, and who is entitled to ensure its protection?

The Seizure Memorandum as Resistance to a Dramatic Revelation

The crowd demands that the chest be opened immediately. Dhruvesh raises the question of a search warrant; Vineet directs attention to official seals, inventories and the necessary procedure. The novel rejects the chance to open the box as if performing a miracle that exposes all mysteries at once. This delay is not merely routine paperwork but an ethical choice of narrative construction. Suspense has arisen from what lies inside, yet its immediate resolution is postponed to protect evidence properly. Even the reader's impatience is measured against the characters' procedural discipline.

Measuring the Soil and Tracing the Body's Footprints

Dhruvesh's shoe sticks in the earth, leaving visible marks of heel and toe, while Ananya records distances, direction and location. As a literary image, the footprint evokes a criminal's body descending upon the earth. At the level of practical investigation, however, it remains a physical trace, not by itself conclusive proof of an offence. The novel holds both possibilities within almost the same moment. In popular experience the earth "speaks"; in a register it becomes measurements, times and locations. This distinction deepens rather than diminishes the literary scene.

Black Ghost and White Apparition at the Periphery

In the darkness by the threshing ground, the black ghost seems to stand as a round presence, the white apparition resembles the gleam on reeds, and the old ghost appears to whisper the memory of an earlier crime into Dhruvesh's ear. The images produce a composite register of actual fear, folk belief and magical realism. At the same time, the outpost worker's inventory, Abhay's soil sample and Ananya's notes constitute another, independent register. The original narrative does not assign both the same evidentiary authority: the ghosts speak the language of the story's conscience; the seizure document speaks the language of official procedure.

The Chest Is Moved, but the Conclusion Is Deferred

The chest is loaded into the outpost vehicle without being opened. Dhruvesh remains standing, the villagers preserve the traces along the dirt road, and a public verdict is deferred. The chapter ends not with "the crime has been proved" but with "an object that was being carried away has been secured." This difference is crucial, since the opening of the box in the following chapter depends on the procedural protection established here. Between the initial frenzy and the final restraint, the narrative's rhythm changes.

Phoolkali's Earth and the Material Restoration of a Name

Phoolkali gathers soil from the threshing ground and later places a speck beside Chhotu's leaf. The metaphor of water now takes root in the earth. The child's name has not merely risen above the water; it has begun to find a place in the soil of his village. Yet this symbolic rite does not automatically alter an administrative report. The novel recognises the distance between emotional restoration and a legal consequence. In the light of that distance, each small symbol becomes a reminder of collective responsibility.

The Final Image of the Shoe and the Coming "Dawn"

The chapter closes upon dew gathering on Dhruvesh's shoe, still trapped in the mud. No one removes it at once; the first light of morning falls upon it. The scene stages no external spectacle of punishment, only a dense interval between shame and evidence. The title "The Dawn Inside the Chest" is announced after this ending, carrying the story from the public drama of the night into the next day's examination room. The passage from darkness to dawn becomes the structural equivalent of an ethical change within narrative time.

Critical Section 300 | Original Chapter 199 — The Dawn Inside the Chest

Opening the Chest: A Cautious Resolution of Suspense

The chest sealed by officials in Chapter 198 is opened the following morning in a small room at the outpost. The narrator does not opt for the spectacle of weapons, piles of money or a criminal's arrest. Instead, we hear the slow scraping as the seal is cut, smell the dampness and follow the inventory of objects one by one. Suspense is thereby transformed into the labour of accountability. The reader's question, "What is inside?" is answered not by a single object but by a layered assemblage of cloth, wage records, forged thumbprints, lists of accounts, electronic devices and a blank space for the next successor.

The Arrangement of Witnesses and the Room's Collective Perspective

Revenue officials, Abhay, Meera, Satyavrat, the children, Phoolkali, Gadadhar, a bank representative and two women entangled in the queen accounts are present. Their diversity prevents the room from becoming the site of one person's celebration of victory. Different social experiences read the scene: officials seek a written inventory, Phoolkali a name, the women their stolen identities, and the children the order in which objects appear. The narrator brings several centres of perception to bear on one object. Just before the ending, the novel's plurality of voices takes the form of a visible arrangement within the room, rather than remaining a theoretical assertion.

Towel, Leaves and Wage Sheet: The Return of Objects from the Beginning

An old gamchha, coconut leaves, torn papers and a bundle tied with red thread lie in the upper layer of the chest. These objects reconnect the narrative to the opening splash, the river and the memory of workers. The smell of the torn cloth, the sheet of damp names and the mother's trembling hands bring different periods into a single room. Rather than a miracle, the renewed encounter with objects forms the narrative's circle. The gamchha is neither merely an emblem of mourning nor independently decisive evidence. Its significance must be established alongside other papers and testimony.

The Disclosure of "Shivnath Sada" and the Inconsistency of Names

The wage sheet in the bundle reads "Shivnath Sada, age sixteen," and Ananya records "Shivnath Sada" as Chhotu's verified real name. Yet Chapter 197 called the same Phoolkali's son "Shivlal, alias Chhotu." The

novel offers no clear connecting account of a renaming, a corrected mistake, two different identities or an institutional change between these names. The irony is pronounced: the final movement, with its ethical demand for accurate names, leaves a central name unstable. Source-faithful criticism can neither erase this discrepancy nor complete the record by inventing an explanation.

Nand Aruni's Diary and the Missing Original

A copy of Nand Aruni's diary is recovered in a file marked "Water Burial—Old," but the whereabouts of the original diary are not made clear. The narrator places the achievement of documentary recovery beside its continuing incompleteness. A signed copy may offer an important thread of memory, yet the missing original does not cease to be a limitation of the investigation. In a novel permeated by copied papers, forged seals and substituted pages, the absence of the original at the end cannot be dismissed as trivial. Once again, the narrative shows the necessity of preserving an acknowledged gap.

Dead Workers and the Cold Word "Eligibility"

Marks indicating "eligibility" for compensation appear beside the names of Bisesar Paswan, Salamat Ansari, Rajnu Mandal and other workers. Devika's response reveals the cruelty of bureaucratic language: death was an experience, whereas eligibility is a category created by an institution. A recurring stylistic device sharpens the novel's social conflict here—the injured voice of the living is placed beside the cold terminology of an office. The narrative does not merely discard official language; it demands that the language be read in the presence of its human consequences.

Queen Accounts and Women's Stolen Thumbprints

The file of queen accounts contains more than twenty women's names, repeated images, multiple accounts and what may be specimens of forged thumbprints. Two of the women present are entitled to inspect their own situations. The central issue is not to turn the women into offenders but to expose a procedure that repeatedly used their names, photographs and thumbprints. The handless apparition of Hulasi set beside a document bearing a forged thumbprint turns magical realism into sharp irony. The tension between an absent hand and a replicated thumb gives formal depth to the narrative's ethical feeling.

Digital Command Files: An Industry That Manufactures Fear through Language

Telephone scripts, fake police insignia, court notices, threats mixing Maithili, Hindi and English, and SIM devices are found together in the iron chest. "Digital" is no longer a vague foreign marvel; its operations become visible through multilingual sentences, equipment, numbers and

the movement of money. The narrator demonstrates that language is the principal instrument by which institutional authority is imitated, and that language can have material consequences in a victim's life. Analysis of voice thus becomes necessary to narratology as well: who is speaking in whose voice?

Dhruvesh's Voice and His Right to Answer

On an old sound recording, a deeper voice follows Madhukar's; Dhruvesh denies that it is his. Satyavrat and Abhay defer any conclusion pending proper technical examination, while recording Dhruvesh's response. Even at a moment of strong feeling, the text does not abolish the other side's right to speak. This is a significant compositional restraint within literature: a person represented as an antagonist is still allowed to answer before the final door of narration closes. Such an opportunity is not proof of legal innocence; it is a requirement of fair narration.

The Circles on the Map and Channa Grove at the Centre

A bag at the bottom contains a map tracing the movement of funds from the bridge site through the Harihar Service Centre, banks and urban accounts to the village. At its centre is a small circle labelled "Channa." To an official, the word is a location marker; to villagers, it denotes a grove that listens. The collision between a governmental and a communal meaning of the same place illuminates the novel's spatial construction. Channa may be a centre or target on the map of wrongdoing, but it is also a centre of inquiry and protection in collective memory. This doubled significance gives place the apparent activity of a character.

The Blank Space for the "Future Successor"

On one page in the chest, the words "future successor" are followed by an empty space after the names of earlier figures of power. Ananya writes "blank space before the public" on her copy. That vacancy becomes the novel's vision of the future: the wrongdoing has been disclosed but may arise again. The narrator resists supplying the next criminal's name in advance. The empty field is not merely an incompleteness in the story; it is a field for civic vigilance. At the same time, the symbolic force of the words written on the copy remains distinct from the practical obligation to protect the original document.

The Empty Chest: The End of an Object and the Beginning of Responsibility

As the contents are packed into separately sealed parcels, the empty chest is turned upside down. Once the belly of collective fear, its inner darkness has now been distributed across inventories, copies, courts and households. The scene declares no victory; it shows responsibilities being divided. Phoolkali changes from being the mother of Chhotu to the mother of a

dead worker whose name has been verified. Yet, powerful as that emotional renaming is, the textual inconsistency of the names remains. The final image pauses at a new alternative: should the grove be made into a monument, or into a living guardian?

Critical Section 301 | Original Chapter 200 — The Guardians of Names

The Establishment of Endless Questions in the Final Chapter

"The Guardians of Names" begins by calling itself the "final chapter," while Meera immediately states that it is not an ending. This double declaration establishes a distinction between the novel's narrative boundary and its social responsibilities. The author halts the sequence of events at Chapter 200, but extends the guardianship of names into the future. The open ending is not a substitute for a plot that has simply been abandoned; it deliberately becomes an inheritance of civic responsibility. Thus the conclusion holds together the opposed meanings of completion and continuity.

Rereading the Opening Title and the Self-Referential Construction

Ananya rewrites "Kabaddi at Channa Grove" on the first page of the register, and Aruni adds "The Village on the Right." Subsequently, the titles of many chapters are read aloud in sequence. The story becomes an archive of its own writing: by reading titles, the characters make the past into a story again. This self-referential arrangement is not self-congratulation but a collective exercise in remembering. The reader receives a signal that the novel's real "sequence" is not merely a timeline but the repeated articulation of people's lived experience.

Shivnath's Sheet and the Return of Motherhood

Phoolkali keeps a copy of Shivnath's sheet, calling it not a death certificate but a page of homecoming. The emotional formulation does not assert a body's return; it expresses the social return of a name. Nevertheless, critical reading must still remember the unresolved gap between "Shivlal, alias Chhotu" in Chapter 197 and "Shivnath Sada" in Chapter 199. The final chapter accepts the later name and proceeds without clarifying the earlier one. To acknowledge this inconsistency critically is precisely to take the novel's demand for accuracy in naming seriously.

The Legal Copy and the Copy Held in Collective Memory

Word arrives that the items from the chest will move from the outpost towards the court, the relevant departments, the investigation and the archives. Meera says that the official process will proceed, but so will the community's work of remembrance. Satyavrat identifies two possible failures: if only court papers survive, living names may be suppressed; if only village names survive and offenders escape legal accountability, justice will remain incomplete. The relationship between these two systems is the novel's final intellectual reconciliation. The narrator neither rejects the

court nor appoints a public assembly as judge. Instead, each level is charged with noticing the other's failures.

New Rules for Kabaddi: From Competition to Remembrance

Once more the children form a circle beneath Channa Grove. Whoever crosses the boundary must return speaking a name. A child who forgets one is not expelled from the game but given another chance to learn it. The game of kabaddi from the beginning has been reconstructed. Formerly, crossing a line tested agility and victory or defeat; at the end it becomes a test of ethical remembrance. The rule change renders the novel's overall development visible within a small folk game. A foundational narrative metaphor becomes a form of social practice.

The Roll of Silences: From External Wrongdoing to Complicity Within

Abhay asks where people should record the names of their own silences, given that the names of offenders will go to court. The answer becomes a list: fear, profit, pretence, superstitious trust in dates and the habit of not reading documents. This turn prevents the final chapter from becoming a declaration that villains have simply been defeated. Examining allegations against Batuknath, Chandrapal, Dhruvesh or Madhavesh was one task; acknowledging the community's own accommodation of shame, caste, convenience and self-interest is another. The victims are not made into flawless heroes. The novel allows collective self-criticism.

Monument or Guardian: The Fundamental Choice

Some wish to build a colourful gate beside the grove, others an enormous slab inscribed with names. Meera and Ananya resist: large names can overshadow smaller ones, while a gate can close a living path. The decision to make small earthen tablets and reserve blank spaces for incomplete names disrupts the centralised heroism of a monumental memorial. The narrator presents remembrance not as an immovable stone object but as a civic practice open to correction. The grove's future lies not in decoration but in its capacity to ask, listen, write and accept newly recovered names.

The Blank Tablet and the Future of Names Yet Unborn

The old ghost seems to inscribe upon an empty tablet letters resembling “the name that has not yet been born.” This is magical realism's last major turn. The duty of remembering the dead is extended towards unknown people of the future. The ghost's intervention does not issue a fresh judicial decree. It is the imaginative language of keeping a place for a future claimant. The open tablet carries the story's ethical time beyond the final date. Rather than promising a permanent solution, it embodies a commitment to remain available.

The Bowl of Water Passing from Hand to Hand

In the final scenes Meera does not empty the bowl. She passes it to Ananya, Ananya to Aruni, and Aruni to a smaller child. The weight of water is physical—cold metal, trembling drops, the bending of a small hand—and its symbolic weight is the continuous obligation of memory. This inheritance is constituted not by family rank or property but by the shared practice of protecting names. At the end the novel does not close its meaning in the hands of one leader, author or official; it places that meaning in the uncertain, shaking yet active hands of another generation.

The Ghost's Umpire's Stick on the Earth and the Living Right to Decide

The old ghost lays the umpire's stick on the ground, signalling that decisions must be left to the living. Throughout the narrative, ghosts have demanded justice in the name of memory, appearing sometimes in kabaddi, sometimes in water, sometimes beside papers. Their withdrawal at the end has extraordinary visual significance: the dead entrust their suffering to the living. This gradual fading of magical presence does not mark the victory of miracles, but the establishment of human responsibility. A new green point upon a dry stump becomes an exceptionally restrained emblem of hope.

Women's Voices, Collective Weeping and Transformation into Song

At the end Phoolkali weeps openly, and the different losses suffered by women flow together like water. Devika transforms the experience into song, joining sounds from the fields, river, court, mobile telephones and grove. The folk-song technique from the opening returns in the final gathering of voices. Such a song does not erase individual grief: one person lost a son, another land, another dignity, and these differences survive. A collective voice signifies not uniformity but the possibility of a space capable of hearing distinct sorrows together.

The Undecided Outcome of Crimes and the Credible Limits of Closure

Chapter 200 makes clear that the papers will go to court, accounts will be investigated, and some of the accused may flee while others are apprehended. No final conviction or complete recovery of money is announced. The force of the word "guardianship" lies in this incompleteness: if every outcome had already been settled, why would citizens need to remain on watch? Instead of ending legal suspense, the narrator chooses the story of society's enduring vigilance. In this sense the open ending has a justification within the plot itself, though it does not automatically excuse particular inconsistencies of names.

“The Story Pauses; It Does Not End”: The Structure of the Epilogue

The final statement closes with the collective utterance “We are here” and a recurring folk song. The original manuscript then contains separate material under “The Book's Final Voice” and in extended appendices. The narrative ending of Chapter 200, the lyric voice of the appended closing passage and the longer appendices should therefore not be mistaken for a single event-filled chapter. The work moves from narrative to archive, from archive to reading, and from reading to a pledge concerning the future. The crocodile is not wholly annihilated. Calling names and preserving evidence become society's new method of resistance.

Inter-Sectional Analysis: From the Meaning of Water Burial to the Guardians of Names

The sequence of Original Chapters 196–200 forms a deliberately arranged concluding arc. “The Meaning of Water Burial” opens the many meanings of the title; “The Names That Rose” locates those meanings in the names spoken again by families; “The Criminal’s Earth” supplies the physical scene of a fleeing object and footprints following the recovery of names; “The Dawn Inside the Chest” gathers objects from different historical periods into one collection; and “The Guardians of Names” turns the entire accumulation into the responsibility of a living community. These five chapters do more than resolve a case: they reread the novel's fundamental metaphors. Water, soil, gamchha, register, seal, telephone, bowl and grove return carrying their earlier meanings, while acquiring additional social significance.

In temporal terms, the ending holds together linear investigation and cyclical memory. Dhruvesh's vehicle sinks into the dirt road at night, outpost employees arrive, a seizure memorandum is prepared, and the chest is opened the next morning: these events are linked by a causal sequence. On the other hand, the joining of three waters in the bowl, an old line from Nand Aruni, the first splash and kabaddi at Channa Grove bring many earlier chapters back into the present. The novel's close does not render these temporal movements antagonistic. Immediate action continues to develop, while memory provides the horizon within which that action can be understood.

With regard to narrative perspective, Ananya and Aruni are no longer merely children at the end. Ananya protects written names, confirmed and incomplete sheets, times and copies; Aruni critically reads questions, measurements, diagrams and symbols. Meera regulates the pace of public emotion; Satyavrat seeks a meeting between the language of government papers and that of the living; Vineet explains the actual limits of electronic

material; and Phoolkali reveals the emotional significance of the sheet bearing a name. None of these perspectives is complete in itself. Final understanding is made by responsibly combining the necessarily incomplete knowledge held in different social positions.

In these five chapters magical realism assumes its decisive form. The black ghost and white apparition seem to appear in the bowl's water or among the reeds of the threshing ground. The water-dweller returns as the dampness of water. The old ghost sets the umpire's stick upon the earth, and a green point emerges from the dry stump. These scenes do not replace official evidence. Their role is to make historical injury, the dead's continuing presence and the living's ethical vigilance perceptible. When the work distinguishes original papers, signatures, seizure lists and family permissions amid these symbols, a particular equilibrium between imagination and documentary practice becomes possible.

The objectification of language is reversed at the end. Formerly, words such as “absent,” “eligible,” “consent,” “special,” “service” and “successor” confined vulnerable people within documents they had not read or been able to speak about. In the last sections the same process of writing takes the forms “correction of names,” “waiting basket,” “roll of silences,” “blank space before the public” and “guardianship of names.” Paper is not itself the enemy. What matters is the responsibility of the person writing on it, the questions of its reader and the family's permission. Through this linguistic transformation the novel communicates its central concern not simply as a proposition but as a form of public conduct.

One genuine textual inconsistency remains clear. Original Chapter 197 names Phoolkali's son “Shivlal, alias Chhotu,” whereas Chapter 199 gives the name “Shivnath Sada” on an old wage sheet and calls it Chhotu's “verified” real name. Chapter 200 adopts the later name without conclusively explaining the relationship between the two. In a work whose central concern is the accurate preservation of names, the significance of this error or unexplained renaming is greater than usual. Criticism cannot erase it, because the inconsistency is an object of analysis. Altering the author’s intended text is not the critic's duty.

Other incompletions fall into two categories. The location of the original diary is still unclear; legal confirmation of numerous financial and acoustic clues remains pending; convictions, recovery of funds and the identity of the future successor are undecided. These are incompletions the narrative openly declares. By contrast, the unbridged difference between Shivlal and Shivnath is a possible compositional inconsistency in the text. It is inappropriate to subsume both under the same label of an “open ending.” Their critical distinction is essential: the meaning of a question

deliberately kept open by the story differs from that of a factual detail altered without explanation.

Ultimately, "The Guardians of Names" does not replace a judicial decision. It establishes the communal capacity to remember. Court papers will proceed through the court; investigative devices will be protected; testimony concerning wounds will be read with the families' permission; and children beside the grove will recite the titles anew each year. As the bowl passes between generations, the conflict of the original novel crosses the boundary of its pages. The book offers no miraculous compensation for the irreversible bodily losses. It places whatever may be preserved—names, forms of address, warnings, questions and public vigilance—into the hands of the future.

Overall Narratological Conclusion: Memory and Living Vigilance

The final basis for assessing the entire narrative is that the storyworld of A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles is confined neither to a single kind of crocodile nor to one physical site of water. The village river, pond, bridge, fields, caste-segregated neighbourhoods, women's thresholds, courthouse veranda, revenue-office register, bank accounts, urban data rooms and mobile-phone voices enter into one another. This breadth is not merely the accumulation of incidents. Every new institutional space gives an old injury a new name: behind death, absence; behind assistance, consent; behind charity, profit; behind authority, fear. “Name” is the continuous device that connects these changing media.

Between the opening splash of water and the final bowl, objects function as instruments of narrative memory. The gamchha marks an absent body; a leaf carries the unstable writing of a name; a seal imitates the authority of an institution; a key expresses unequal access; dust preserves the pressure of a removed sheet; a pen drive records the theft of a voice; the bowl joins the histories of three streams; and an empty tablet reserves space for names of the future. This succession of objects gives a body to the expansive narrative. Amid so many characters and events, familiar objects repeatedly open a doorway to earlier memories for the reader.

Community assemblies, performances, folk songs, witness statements, documentary readings, journeys and children's questions recur in the narrative's structure. Their advantage is that the narrator's solitary judgement is questioned by many social voices. Meera, Surmani Devi, Devika, Ananya, Aruni, Satyavrat, Bhikhari Lal, Phoolkali, boatmen, women and unnamed witnesses fashion the meaning of the story out of their limited experiences. There is also a weakness in the arrangement: many chapters repeatedly begin with a moral aphorism, a folk song, a scene, a conclusion of inquiry and a gesture towards the next chapter in a similar order. Repetition sometimes becomes structural rhythm; at other times it risks reducing the uncertainty specific to different characters.

Multilayered time is one of the work's principal narrative strengths. The bridge disaster of thirty years ago, survey registers from fifteen years ago, countless court dates, newer digital fraud and the ordered investigation from night to dawn are placed within one present. Time is not merely a chronological list. It becomes palpable in ageing bodies, the stump in the grove, the wait for compensation, the water-dweller's folk tale and the fading ink of a page. Yet in so long a narrative, the consistency of

characters' ages, their generational positions and the intervals between incidents still deserves further editorial examination.

The discussion of inconsistency is especially important to this study. Some contradictions are deliberately staged within the story: a document says "absent," while a living body testifies to presence; aid is promised onstage while rights are later surrendered; an official seal is forged; an imitated voice uses the fear attached to real relationships; and one person is represented through multiple counterfeit names. These contradictions generate narrative. By contrast, names that change without cause across chapters, or incompatible details concerning a single character's history, demand editorial scrutiny. In particular, the difference between "Shivlal, alias Chhotu" and "Shivnath Sada" in the final movement touches the central idea of the guardianship of names. It cannot be dismissed merely as a symbol. Criticism must not rewrite the author's text, but it must draw a clear line between meaning produced by narration and inconsistencies in the text.

Magical realism does more here than provide images of ghosts and apparitions. The dead remain at the edge of the present, yet consent from victims, responses from the accused, the protection of documents and the dignity of public hearings remain in the hands of living characters. At the end the old ghost puts down the umpire's stick. This gesture becomes the work's final passage from visual wonder to civic responsibility. The dead cannot dispense justice by themselves, but they can continue to make the living uncomfortable with forgetfulness. In this undertone, the many forms of the crocodile become connected.

The contribution of the women's perspective is not restricted to pity for victims. Across matters of shelter, medicine, grain, debt, thumbprints, women's queues, distorted names, telephone threats, privacy and public reading, female characters devise methods of resistance. Meera prevents hasty violent judgement; Surmani Devi protects the dignity of names; Devika distinguishes theatrical performance from the performance of crime; and Phoolkali lends an absent name the meaning of a homecoming. Nevertheless, whether women's speech, actual decision-making power and social outcomes receive comparable depth in every chapter remains a proper subject for the editorial survey of an expanded future edition.

The work offers no simple substitution of a people's court for state law, or vice versa. In most scenes Channa Grove is a place to listen, question and protect documents; the authority to determine guilt and impose punishment remains with official legal procedures. Hence the unresolved legal action at the conclusion is not merely a narrative deficiency; it also acknowledges the limits of communal remembrance. Yet no specific case

whose outcome remains unshown may be declared to have achieved "complete justice." The study's conclusion must preserve a clear distinction: social vigilance has been established; many stages of legal redress remain unfinished.

The story's final achievement is visible in the guardianship of names: the right to speak paired with the right to remain silent; a plate of verified names beside a basket of names awaiting verification; acquired evidence accompanied by an account of its limits; and remembrance of the dead beside an empty tablet for the unborn. These four pairs condense the novel's intellectual complexity. In the final song, "We are here" is not merely an emotional affirmation of existence. It carries a new obligation to join that utterance, day after day, to evidence, caution, mutual assistance and memory in public life. The story pauses on the page; the obligation to call names continues in the hands of the living.

Gajendra Thakur, A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles, Complete Trilogy, original Maithili manuscript, Chapters 108–200.

Final Critical Chapter: How Inconsistency Becomes a Narrative Method

Making Inconsistency an Object of Study

The narrative of A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles brings many narrative times, generations, neighbourhoods, bodies of water, courts, folk festivals, documents and digital devices into a single expansive field of composition. On such a scale, when the reader encounters two versions of the same event, several written forms of one name, or different meanings attached to the same symbol, it would be critically unsound to regard every difference as the same kind of "mistake." A character may deliberately lie; the narrator may adopt one character's restricted knowledge and subsequently overturn it; a record may itself have been altered through forgery; and the writing of a manuscript may also contain an inadvertent, substantial error. Distinguishing these four situations is the first condition of a reliable evaluation of this novel.

Inconsistency becomes a narrative method when its recurrence genuinely changes the story's focus, focalisation, ethical stakes or the reader's activity. A mere mismatch of names is insufficient. If the conflict between two versions obliges the reader to examine different sources, assess a character's credibility, or understand how truth is produced within the story, the difference organises the labour of reading. But if a discrepancy remains without acknowledgement, questioning or consequence within the narrative, it should not automatically be acquitted as a modernist experiment.

Two Distinct Planes: Story Material and Narrative Arrangement

On one plane are the events recounted: flood, tree, field, lost names, theatre, consent notebook, court dates, telephone threats, service ceremonies and river ghats. On another plane lies the arrangement through which these events are told: the narrator's ordering, anticipatory folk songs, children's registers, a second play within a play, someone's testimony, the rereading of old papers, and social reality abruptly appearing amid magical scenes. A difference of dates or names within the story material may itself be a dispute in the fictional world; in narrative arrangement, the decisive question becomes the perspective from which the reader encounters that difference.

In narratological terms, the sequence in which events occurred need not be the sequence in which they are presented. Anticipation, retrospective recollection, expanded scene, summary, pause and retelling give a single

life several narrative forms. In this work, fifteen years recorded in an old survey register and a single hour of a recent telephone call illuminate one another. Information from the past arrives late, whereupon the present event is read again in a different light. This temporal non-equivalence is a powerful method of the narrative; nevertheless, an explicit conflict between dates cannot in every case be justified by invoking a disruption of narrative time.

The Structural Opposition between Records and Lived Life

One of the novel's principal narrative devices is that the living person disputes what an official record says that person is. Although Sona is marked absent on paper, she recounts how she was bodily present on the relevant date; consent is entered in a dead person's name; indications of a death certificate arise for the living Nageshwar Jha; and papers concerning shelter, medicine, grain and scholarships turn into waivers of land rights or assent to silence. These differences are not accidental coincidences encountered by the reader. They occupy the centre of the novel's action.

The gap between the formal authority of the record and a character's experience propels the plot. A page of a register first provokes suspicion; it is then compared, separately, with an old family photograph, a witness's recollection, a date, a seal, a carbon impression, a bank slip and the wording of a statement. In this sequence, difference itself motivates investigation. Suspending the seemingly decisive pronouncement of an authoritative register, the narrator draws many small voices into the centre of narration. Thus the inconsistency between "documentary truth" and "bodily truth" is a constructed conflict of the storyworld, not a minor editorial oversight.

Polyphonic Testimony and Restricted Focalisation

Meera, Ananya, Aruni, Devika, Surmani Devi, Satyavrat Mehta, Ramballabh, Bhikhari Lal, Kamala and other characters see the same event from different positions. One reads a date; another recognises fear in a voice; one examines a field's boundary; another registers the trembling of a body. When the narrator brings these restricted forms of knowledge before us one after another, readers make meaning amid numerous incomplete accounts rather than receiving a single, omniscient, definitive sentence. Unequal accounts are therefore a constitutive condition of this multiply focalised arrangement.

Polyphonic narration does not, however, mean that every voice establishes reality with equal authority. The novel's community archive repeatedly distinguishes what was "seen," what was "heard," and what was "inferred." In Chapters 171–172, the separation of red, yellow and black threads

provides a visual form for this narrative distance. The limits of direct experience, the mediation involved in another person's report, and the historical conditions of a person's fear are kept distinct, leaving readers responsible for arriving at a conclusion. In this way inconsistency becomes more than indecision: it becomes a method of disciplined listening.

A Play within a Play: Another Stage for Truth

In the Videha Theatre Festival of Chapters 133–137, performance does not merely depict society; it establishes a new narrative level within the story. The dramatic script asks the audience to regard itself as "witnesses"; after the production, the experience of applause and silence opens a path for actual villagers to offer their testimony. The suffering "enacted" in the play is not identical to the suffering "lived" by the spectators. Precisely because a distance remains between them, the social significance of the characters' experiences becomes apparent.

The order of scenes proposed by the dramatic script and the account of the actual performance do not entirely correspond. Criticism must read this difference on two levels. First, text and stage are different media and therefore permit narrative rearrangement. Second, wherever the text offers no explanation for the changes, the possibility of a genuine editorial inconsistency in scene order remains. The distinction between the actor Satyavrat and Satyavrat as a figure in the storyworld also demands care. Declaring these differences to be "planned dramatic fragmentation" without textual evidence would not increase the play's force; it would diminish the reliability of criticism.

Recurrence: Not Mere Repetition, but Altered Consequence

In the novel, assemblies repeatedly gather at Channa Grove; names are read again; testimony is once more preserved. Scenes in kitchens and around shared plates also return in neighbouring chapters. The narratological question posed by recurrence is whether the situation changes when the same action occurs for a second time. If the first communal meal tests whether people of different castes can sit together, while the next interrogates the limits of shared labour or family, the same physical action becomes a different ethical event. Where a new scene produces no consequence different from its predecessor, the slackness of repetition must also be acknowledged.

In Chapters 125–126, after rice is planted at night, a glimpse of ripened grain appears the following morning without an explicit interval of time. Magical realism or a compression of narrative duration is possible, particularly because the figurative activity of soil and seed recurs throughout the work. Yet the textual question remains whether the

narrator explains this departure from the actual agricultural calendar. It would be improper to force the moment into either of two categories—an effortless miracle or an obvious printing error.

The Stories of Objects: Seals, Shawls, Dust, Carbon and Telephones

Many objects in the narrative acquire new meanings when they pass into another character's hands after an ordinary act. A shawl is first an award at a service ceremony; later it becomes the material through which the relationship between the ceremony's stage and private rights is examined. A seal once bears the impression of legitimacy, then reveals the possibility of counterfeit legitimacy. Dust in a courtroom ceases to be useless matter and appears as a sign of tampering. The impression left by carbon paper becomes the memory of a removed page. A telephone changes from a means of family contact into an observation chamber of invisible confinement.

These transformations in the meanings of objects also train the reader's gaze. What initially seemed symbolic may subsequently become a material object with evidentiary possibilities; what appeared to be evidence alone may disclose a symbol of ethical violence. In this way the narrator does not set social criticism apart like a separate essay, but weaves it into the characters' acts of lifting, looking, safeguarding and reading. This sequence of objects is a principal achievement of the narrative method formed through recurrence and inconsistency.

Multiple Forms of the Name and the Politics of Identity

The sequence "Madhukar Madhav Mishra," "Madhavesh," "Madhvesh" and "Master" deserves study. Changes in naming distinguish a character's private social past, the identity adopted in the city and the role performed in wrongdoing. One name is associated with the shame of childhood, another with newfound credibility in the marketplace, a third with a professional role in acting. This multiplicity of names is disclosed through the progress of the narrative investigation. It is not simply a minor difference in spelling.

A different example is the name Chhotu in Chapters 197 and 199. At one point we find "Shivlal, alias Chhotu"; later, on the evidence of a page, we encounter "Shivnath Sada." The original text provides no definite explanation of the relationship between these two names. To assert automatically that they were secret names of the same person would be to invent a bridge between them. An inconsistency of this kind should remain explicitly identified in criticism; if an authenticated comparison of authorial texts becomes available, standardisation of names or an

explanation might become a matter for editorial work. Filling the gap with reconstructed fictional facts is not literary criticism.

The Limits of Metaphorical Geography

The village river, pond, embankment, Tetri Ghat, the stump in the grove and the court veranda each serve their own symbolic purpose in the novel. A crocodile seen in the water and a crocodile figured in the glass of a mobile phone become different incarnations of the same predatory power. By shifting locations, the novel suggests that injustice lives not only in water but also in service offices, the language of documents, the lanes of banks and the impersonation of voices.

Nevertheless, Chapter 166 is entitled "The Storehouse at Imli Ghat," whereas the narrative repeatedly refers to the warehouse buildings at Tetri Ghat. Since the plot does not clearly establish either two separate ghats or two names for the same ghat, this constitutes a genuine inconsistency in place names. If criticism were to treat it as a planned technique of multiple geographies, the limits of the concrete description would fail to support that claim. This is precisely where a distinction is necessary between narrative metaphor and a geographical reference that can be corrected editorially.

The Language of Colours and Its Self-Contradiction

The three threads of testimony—red, yellow and black—establish the categories of what was seen, heard and suspected within the narrative. Yet the opening song of Chapter 172 mentions a green thread alongside the red and yellow. It remains possible that the colour imagery of the folk song and the classification adopted by the assembly for justice belong to two cultural levels. At this particular point, however, the text does not explain why green changes to black. The symbolic independence of the song is therefore a plausible interpretation, not a definitive resolution.

This divergence of colours also supplies a useful critical test. If the folk song is calling for black fear to be transformed into the living green of memory, the text requires an event that supports that reading; where such a link is absent, an editorial discrepancy remains. Readers may perceive a multilayered work of art, but critics have no right to impose an interpretation for which evidence is lacking. Such restraint is itself a living practice of narratology.

Supernatural Vision and the Limits of Decisiveness

The old-man ghost, the black ghost, the white spectre, the drowned spirit, birds and crocodiles appear repeatedly within the storyworld. At times characters perceive their shadows; at others they remain features of

collective imagination or folk belief alone. Through these differences of perception, the novel declines to fix one exclusive boundary between reality and imagination. Instead of issuing a final command about what an inquiry must decide, supernatural presences make visible the endurance of memory, the absent rights of the dead, and a community's ethical fear.

Magical realism succeeds most fully when a supernatural sign does not release a character from practical work. Meera repeatedly keeps popular perceptions distinct from written evidence; a person is not declared guilty because a crocodile appears to point towards them; the consent of a family, comparison of names in writing, and the conditions for preserving records securely all remain necessary. Within this duality, the story's magic is not the antithesis of human procedures of justice but a resonance of memory accompanying them.

The Ethics of Narration: No One's Suffering as Spectacle

Tension repeatedly arises in the novel between the publicity of testimony and an individual's privacy. The story of a woman who sought shelter, an elderly woman defrauded over a mobile phone, a widow subjected to a forged signature, or an account operated in a dead person's name may all be relevant to public inquiry; yet the details of private suffering do not automatically become public material. Meera's insistence on seeking consent, keeping names confidential and describing only the method of the crime establishes an ethical boundary for narration in this work.

Such restraint matters from a narratological perspective. The narrator's potential omniscience does not confer unlimited rights over the private lives of characters. Leaving something unsaid may itself be a meaningful narrative event—but its meaning may arise from a character's autonomy rather than an obstruction of information. If a new reader finds an account incomplete, the question arises whether this is authorial postponement, silence chosen by the victim, or a lack of sources necessary for a conclusion. Without distinguishing these possibilities, it would be careless to describe silence either as weak storytelling or as the whole truth.

Inconsistency at the Ending: Not a Verdict, but the Beginning of Vigilance

The final chapters extend the meaning of "water burial" from physical submersion to social forgetting. Water from three rivers in a bowl, separate arrangements for recovered and unverified names, lawful inspection of the chest, and the appointment of guardians of names at the grove together fashion an ending in which the story does not announce total victory. Numerous convictions, the recovery of money, final control over the criminal network and future social repair remain undecided. Here

undecidedness is an ethical strategy of the plot, because protecting truth is not a single celebration but sustained labour.

Yet an open ending does not make all of its incompletions meaningful simply by being open. What happened to a particular person, when a given file was formally admitted in law, or what relationship exists between two names—these factual questions are not self-evidently instances of narrative indeterminacy. When the work does not provide a concrete outcome, criticism must identify its limit. When it keeps a question open in order to create active remembrance, rights and future obligations, criticism may recognise the artistic achievement of the open ending.

Final Judgment: Inconsistency, Method and the Attentive Reader

The novel's most powerful narrative originality lies in creating a public story in which discordant voices are not erased but brought into mutual scrutiny. Register and body, stage and life, old genealogical record and new SIM card, the voice of a real family member and the sound of an impersonating official, popular perception and written verification: each of these oppositions drives the work towards another event. Readers themselves examine differences of name, time, testimony and focalisation. Participation in the flow of the story thus becomes not merely emotional identification but critical reading.

Its limitation is that dense recurrence, an unspecified scene sequence in one or two places, jumps between seasons, changes of colour, ghat names and such small factual inconsistencies as Chhotu's name cannot necessarily be established as deliberate forms of narrative art. Identifying them is not an act of opposition to the author; it is an act of fairness to the reader. Appropriate publication editing could check textual variants against the original at such points. Criticism, however, need not silently repair its source text or add invented explanations.

Ultimately, "inconsistency" is two things at once in this work: the creative coexistence of unequal narratives within a living society, and certain real textual irregularities that remain within an expansive composition. The first produces a plurality of social knowledge; the second calls for editorial care. Keeping them separate allows us to understand why A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles does not hand its readers a final answer. Instead, it trains them to become guardians of names. A story that asks readers to examine the very conditions of its telling becomes not only an object of memory but also a method of making memory.

Epilogue: The Guardians' Work Is Not Unfinished, but Continuous

The story is complete in the sense that it does not surrender ownership of its final truth to the reader. Rather, it gives readers the capacity to listen attentively, keep names accurate, acknowledge incompletion and understand the necessary distance between evidence and feeling. If the narrative's inconsistency arises between different testimonies within society, it is a creative force of narration. If it persists as an unexplained contradiction concerning a concrete name, place or date, identifying it is criticism's duty. The joint accomplishment of these two tasks opens a path towards a literarily responsible reading of the vast storyworld of A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles.

Maithili Narrative Theory / Volume III

PART III | THE INNER LIFE OF NARRATIVE

Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind: A Complete Narratological Study of All 216 Chapters

Critical Work: Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind — A Complete Narratological Study

Primary Text: Kurukshetram Antarmanak [Maithili novel]. Original author: Gajendra Thakur. First edition of the original work: 2019.

Language of the original critical study: Maithili. Format: 6 × 9 inches. Subjects: narrative structure, narrative time, focalisation, polyphony, intertextuality, memory, labour and narrative inconsistency.

This critical edition contains textual analyses of all 216 chapters of the novel, combined reviews of its narrative divisions, and a separate concluding examination of the narratological significance of inconsistency.

Critical Introduction: Work, Evidence and Method

The story of Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind begins with a situation that seems impossible but becomes possible within an administrative system of records: Sarita, a living woman, receives notice of her own death. To regard this merely as the opening of a mystery would diminish the real critical possibilities of the novel's first four chapters. The question is not only who sent the false notice. It is also how much authority a sentence written by the administration acquires in the face of a living person's knowledge, body, labour, memory and familial relationships. The kitchen fire, water at the doorway, a train whistle, a gate pass, a boatman's bamboo pole and clothes at the river landing are objects in the fictional world; each also marks a particular limit of evidence and social time.

Across the first four chapters, the narrative progressively enlarges its field. In the first, the record of a life clashes with domestic and family existence in the kitchen. In the second, a private sheet bearing twenty-seven names becomes an ethical dispute about the public use of documents and personal safety. In the third, Fakira's livelihood and the organisation of public routes become an independent sequence of events. In the fourth, an ancient narrative strand involving Satyavati and Devavrata and the modern Tilwaha river landing appear in succession within a single chapter. To describe this merely as a movement from a 'small story' to a 'large story' is insufficient: every expansion changes the character of the evidence already encountered. From domestic testimony to public paperwork, and from there to the physical measurement of a river, the grounds on which a claim rests grow steadily more difficult to assess.

In this study, 'story' denotes the inferred sequence of situations occurring in the characters' lives, while 'narration' denotes the order, duration, voice and focalisation through which those events are presented in the text. The examination of analepsis, prolepsis, scene, summary and narrative pause is informed by Gérard Genette's questions about narrative time, but techniques absent from the novel will not be treated as if they were present. Bakhtin's dialogic perspective helps us examine the relation among multiple voices in a society; the mere presence of several conversations does not prove an achieved artistic polyphony. Wayne Booth's discussions of readerly trust and narratorial reliability raise the question of whom the reader should believe, and how quickly. The concerns of Indian poetics with dhvani, propriety (aucitya) and rasa accompany the reader's construction of meaning and emotional experience, even though the chapters do not everywhere stage explicit theoretical disputation.

The relationship between evidence and narration has not been introduced simply to attach Sanskrit labels to contemporary administrative forms. Direct experience, another person's statement, the provenance of a record, conditions governing an inference, the limits of what is unavailable, and doubt must first be identified in the distinct forms they assume within the text. Here the perspective of Videha Parallel History is not a predetermined decree about the past but a method of questioning: whose work, journeys, songs and silences survive outside government registers? And why should private memory or popular testimony be exempt from critical scrutiny? The rewriting of the ancient Mahabharata is likewise an ethical dialogue between an inherited story and a modern narrative, not a doctrine of literal reincarnation.

Chapter 1 — The Kitchen of the Dead

The First Collision between a Living Body and the Register of the Dead

The opening establishes its narrative opposition in a single sentence: a notice of Sarita's death arrives while she is searching in a rice container for a prescription belonging to her husband, who died seventeen years earlier. Three times are compressed into that sentence: the husband's actual death seventeen years ago, yesterday's record of medicine dispensed in his name, and Sarita's death, formally declared two days earlier. The narrator does not select a culprit in advance; the reader must discover the problem through discordant dates and the presence of a living person. The contradiction is certainly arresting, but the novel's actual narrative movement is to turn it away from an immediate solution to a mystery and towards a systemic examination of evidence.

Rice boiling over on the stove establishes a significant counterpoint to the notice. On hearing the news, Sarita first reduces the flame, puts water on to heat and tells Bittu to go to school. Ordinary actions continue, without a theatrical declaration, in the face of an official notice pronouncing her life at an end. Yet cooking rice does not by itself constitute formal proof, acceptable to the government, that someone is biologically alive—a distinction made explicit in Naira's own dialogue. It would therefore be a mistake to fix the kitchen's meaning solely as a 'symbol' of life. It is a tangible location for the household's timetable, the quantity of work performed, reciprocal familial duties and resistance to the institution's demand for immediate compliance.

Register of Events: What Actually Changes?

The first change is the receipt of a death notice, not a death. The second is the discovery of a recent medicine-dispensation slip in the dead husband's name, dividing the initial suspicion into two distinct problems of record-keeping. The third is Naira's initiation of a correction procedure: the application form offers no category for a daughter, and after the option 'authorised representative' it requires consent from the person listed as dead. A fourth change is the arrival of independent testimony that Fakira's entry pass has been blocked. The fifth is Naira's creation of three separate groups of evidence: her mother's living presence, medicine received under the dead husband's name, and Fakira's dispute at the gate. The sixth is an acknowledgement of receipt of the application, not an official correction of Sarita's status. Finally Sarita's statement, 'My name is not the only one caught in this,' opens the informational chain of the next chapter. It has not yet been established that all these events form a single causal sequence.

Of particular importance is the distance between 'application received' and 'certified alive'. In many mystery narratives, a protagonist's first successful application would signal the beginnings of a solution. Here only the first rung of administrative acknowledgement has been reached. The reason Fakira's gate was closed also remains uncertain. The chapter itself allows that 'it might have been a coincidence—or a conspiracy', opening the possibility of inference without passing through that opening to a conclusion. Its force lies not in hastily identifying an offender but in practising the separation of questions that must not yet be conflated.

Narrative Time, Focalisation and the Organisation of Knowledge

The narrator speaks in the third person; nothing indicates that the narrator is present as a character within the story. The narration has access both to Sarita's memory and to Naira's inward responses. For example, it summarises the history of repeated reliance on death certificates for pensions, land and ration entitlements during Sarita's seventeen years of widowhood; it also relates Naira's contract work and her uncertainty about her mother's safety. Rather than claim a fixed, omniscient focalisation, it is more accurate to speak of a shifting closeness to characters from scene to scene. Events generally advance from morning to afternoon on a single day; a brief analepsis concerning the husband's death increases their social weight. The train's sound, the kitchen fire and the correction page with its deadline repeatedly re-establish the present.

One important justification of the narrator's position is that it establishes the limits of the characters' knowledge. Naira sees standing water, but does not immediately invent a 'cause' for the blocked drainage. She notices an institutional resemblance between Fakira's gate pass and her mother's death notice, but does not turn that resemblance into an unwarranted causal conclusion. From the perspective of poetics, this may suggest more than an injunction: the unseen cause of apparently wet earth cannot be discovered with the eye's observation of a single day. Nevertheless, the caution is stated directly in many passages, and its dramatic consequences will require further examination.

Perception, Testimony and Inference: A Limited Narratological Dialogue

In her notebook, Naira writes 'direct perception' beside what she has seen and 'information received' beside what appeared on the telephone. This is one of the novel's clearest internal acts of classifying evidence. The ground of direct perception is that Naira is physically in her mother's presence; the ground of received information is a digital text from a service claiming that her mother has died. These two conflicting statements do not automatically cancel one another, because the conditions under which the

knowledge originated are different. The dispensing of medicine under her dead father's name warrants an inference that the record should be investigated for irregularity; it does not yet warrant the conclusion that a particular person committed fraud. A missing name or incomplete page is not proof that a person does not exist.

In the language of inference, terms such as paksha (subject of inference), sadhya (what is to be established), hetu (reason) and vyapti (invariable concomitance) cannot be presented here as a complete formal inferential structure: the novel has not yet composed a classical five-membered syllogism. What it does expose is the error of drawing conclusions in excess of the evidence. The record says 'medicine received', but the recipient is unknown; it records 'death', yet a living body stands before us; it recognises an 'authorised representative', yet has no official category for the relationship of daughter. In this disparity, reasoning is not the enemy of life; it becomes a form of discernment opposed to forcing life into a false category.

Women's Labour, Privacy and the Politics of Records

The absence of 'daughter' from a form offering 'husband', 'son' and 'authorised representative' is a precise point of social criticism. Naira can use her technical competence to complete an application, but the system does not recognise her relationship as a daughter among its primary categories. Sarita can read and decide matters concerning her own life, yet she confronts the contradiction of a system that demands the consent of a person it has already declared dead. This is more than satire upon a technical error; it dramatises an unequal linguistic classification operating between civic existence and family rights.

The dispute about privacy is likewise driven by Sarita's active decisions. She insists that the original paper remain with her, that copies be made, that the family address not be circulated everywhere, and that the difference between 'correcting' something and 'showing it to everyone' be understood. Sarita is thus not a passive source of information, but a character who defines limits on the circulation of knowledge. Naira's profession involves opening old records; her mother's life teaches her that protecting certain names may also require delaying publication. This distinction is an ethical seed of the novel's potential contribution to Videha Parallel History: a suppressed history should not be reread at the cost of destroying the consent of the person from whom it comes.

Language, Rasa-Dhvani and the Limits of the First Chapter

The dialogue is brief, its responses sharp and interwoven with household tasks. A remark such as 'The news of death can wait for the rice' produces

both humour and ethical insistence amid an apparent death. Fakira's question about eating rice is not an appeal for pity; it offers a piece of popular reasoning against the contradiction of death in the register. A yellow flower petal in a brass container makes an old bereavement felt without an extended explanation, drawing the reader into the memory of the dead husband. The pathetic and the comic do not cancel one another here; their coexistence reveals the meaning of life's inconsistent accounting.

The critical limitation is nevertheless clear. From the beginning, Naira and Sarita repeatedly make exemplary distinctions between inference and evidence. Their skill has a plausible basis in their professions and experience, but supplying the reader at once with the 'correct method' for each dispute may reduce the narrative's uncertainty. Fakira's speech, too, often assumes the form of a precisely formulated ethical maxim, leaving a tension between the representation of a living personality and the exposition of an idea. Before pronouncing this a decisive flaw, one must observe how far later chapters allow the characters to reveal disagreement, error and incomplete decisions. The first chapter's achievement can be stated more modestly and firmly: beneath the guise of a mystery, it opens a concrete story of civic existence and responsibility for records, not a solved case.

Chapter 2 — Twenty-Seven Names

Ethical Ownership of Records and the Right to Silence

The scene of papers being dried instead of rice on the following morning is the chapter's first important transformation. In Chapter 1, the kitchen was a space of domestic life set against administrative records; in Chapter 2, the papers themselves find protection in the kitchen. Sarita spreads out old newspapers, places brass bowls on all four corners, and dries the damp sheets. This slow activity does not stop the narrative's momentum; it introduces the reader's impatience to uncover the next mystery into the time required by a human being's responsibility. The page must be preserved before its names can be read.

The sheet carries twenty-seven personal names, different inks, dates and signs, crossed-out lines and a final fold that remains closed. Sarita immediately resists assigning a single meaning to the list. Not everyone named is dead; not all their papers are wrong. Some names are correct but their relationships wrongly entered; some individuals have changed their names; others were listed without consent. Without acknowledging these differences, it would be wrong to treat the sheet as a 'register of the dead', a 'list of criminals', or an infallible key to a mystery. The number twenty-

seven, foregrounded in the title, is not the final destination of the events: the list contains diverse names, work, corrections and uncertainties.

Sequence of Events: From a Concealed Name to a Public Threat

The first event is the opening of a handwritten sheet belonging to Sarita, on which she authorises the viewing of twenty-six names while one remains concealed. The second is Sarita's written record of the decision to maintain secrecy; it establishes that the reason for withholding a name is the source's wish, not her daughter's whim. The third is Sanket's repair of a phone and his account of private rights over photographs, giving fresh practical grounds for distinguishing the making of a copy from limited disclosure. The fourth is the copying of twenty-six names while leaving the twenty-seventh space blank and recording the character of the evidence. The fifth is a threatening telephone call in an unknown male voice. The sixth is Naira's decision to write down the threat separately, inform the police and continue her investigation without publishing the sheet without permission. No report to the police is actually filed in the chapter; the distinction between a decision and a completed action must be preserved.

The last sentence of the threat speaks of putting out the stove. Rice in the first chapter thereby becomes an explicit risk to subsistence. Yet the caller's identity remains unknown, as does whether he knows the name in the closed fold or how he acquired information about the sheet. The narrative creates uncertainty without yet providing enough facts to test it. Naira writes down the time, digits and words she heard; she does not invent an identity for the voice. This discipline places an ethical control upon the mystery.

Narrative Voice, Duration and the Function of Delay

From the opening to the middle of this second chapter, time is expanded with care. The time needed to make tea, wet firewood, consent to unfolding a sheet, the memory of a three-day entry receipt, the midday meal and Sanket's minor repair are not merely ways of filling the clock: they are preconditions for decisions. Sarita does not disclose the mystery at once, and the narration does not arrogate to itself a right to disclose it on her behalf. The delay between the reader's curiosity and the character's refusal may become an ethics of narration, rather than a superficial device of suspense. Yet the narrator repeatedly explains the substance of a character's thoughts—for example, the mother's willingness to endure her daughter's distrust—and thus sometimes narrows the space in which readers might draw their own inferences.

Memory is handled with similar caution. When an old notebook yields an incident involving a red flower in childhood, Sarita remarks that not every old mark is a mystery. The novel mocks the excesses of its own established mystery technique. If every flower, stain, drop or sound is treated as a secret sign, the ordinariness of everyday life disappears. This small piece of domestic laughter strengthens the story's credibility. Such restraint is a literary achievement, particularly when a chapter is already furnished with the attraction of an enigmatic number in its title, 'Twenty-Seven Names'.

Evidence, Confidentiality and the Ethical Counterargument

Sarita's instruction to keep the fold closed initially appears to conflict with Naira's archival profession. Naira thinks verification will be difficult without examining the original. Sarita's response—begin with twenty-six names—is not a prohibition on a full investigation but an ethical limit on its stages. The important change occurs when Naira asks for written permission and Sarita herself dates and records her decision about confidentiality. Through that act, the source's wishes, the copyist's responsibility and future review become three distinct matters. Who made a copy, what was concealed, and on whose instructions can all be recorded without disclosing the name.

The decision does not become an absolute principle. Sarita herself asks what happens if withholding the name leads to an accusation against an innocent person. The novel thus recognises the danger of making privacy an eternal moral commandment. On one side stands personal safety, on the other justice for an accused person: this is the real centre of its narrative ethics. Naira's provisional response—if an indication of harm arises, she will first inform her mother; she will not accuse without evidence—is neither an impartial nor a complete solution. It is a proposal for procedural ethics. A final determination of culpability and rights depends on events still to come.

Narratologically, the episode has a limited connection with the delimitation of knowledge and the boundaries of evidence. A 'crossed line beside a name' has been seen, but its meaning is disputed: it does not necessarily mean 'correction completed'. An 'entry receipt' proves entry, not a successful hearing. Identical spelling does not, without corroboration, establish that two entries refer to the same person. The content of a document is therefore distinguished from the reach of the inferences it permits. Narratively, the advantage is that instead of one explosive revelation, a list of several incomplete human tasks, each of a different kind, emerges.

Sanket's Episode: Technology, Privacy and the Next Generation

Sixteen-year-old Sanket replaces a button on an old mobile phone, while acknowledging the limits of his skill: replacing a button will not bring back a lost photograph. When the number printed on the back of a textbook appears publicly in a school group photograph, his objection makes the right to privacy more than an adult matter. He does not accept 'everyone is sending it' as adequate justification. His advice to cover the private portion before taking a photograph forms part of a practical social ethic. At the same time, a young learner's independent voice emerges: the story does not confine authority over technology to Naira's professional expertise.

There is, however, a critical risk in this scene. Sanket arrives just when a policy of confidential copying is taking shape, and his speech is so orderly that the needs of an instructional example may overpower the spontaneity of his presence. The distinct emotional world of his adolescence does not become deeply visible; his technical intelligence supports the narrative's ethical conclusion. Whether later chapters give Sanket other desires, mistakes, objections or an independent story remains a legitimate critical question.

Standing Water, the Domestic Fire and the Chapter's Assessment

Watching water standing beside the wall and a child's paper boat floating in it, Naira considers the possibility of a drainage outlet, but reaches no certain judgment about the cause. The direction of the water calls for physical inspection; it is not yet proven to be a forewarning of a specified disaster. The final scene holds together a relit household stove and the protected sheets. Even after the threat has become a direct verbal assault upon subsistence, the family does not suspend the preparation of food. In this way the first chapter's kitchen resistance becomes the difficult beginning of public work conducted under the protection of privacy.

The chapter's particular success is that, even while making the unknown twenty-seventh name an object of curiosity, it refuses to imply that secrecy is innocent simply by being secrecy. The unresolved ethical question, the verification of the disclosed copies, the independent status of the threat and the mother's real fear all furnish the story with energy for the next chapter. Its limitation is that several characters express methodological caution with almost identical lucidity; the work still has room for greater variety of dialogic tones and more uncomfortable silences.

Chapter 3 — Time at the Crossroads

Civic Identity, Mobility and the Unequal Distribution of Time

Sarita's family was at the centre of the first two chapters, with Fakira appearing as a visitor. The third chapter enters his crossroads, earnings, routes of travel and distinct identity. In the opening scene the tea seller takes the kettle off the fire for a third time, but Fakira's glass remains untouched. The supposed silence after the train begins to be heard from within as the sound of basket cane, wheels in the mud and milk containers. Instead of a predominantly visual description of the town, a map of labour unfolds through sound. This is not merely a reproduction of Fakira's private perception: the narrator brings the crossroads' unseen labour to the reader through its noises.

Fakira has three sources of income—telling travellers the time and the way, payment for carrying bundles, and assistance he sometimes requests —and the narrative deliberately keeps them distinct. No preconceived middle-class morality that would call begging dishonourable is imposed upon him; equally, it rejects dismissing wages for work as charity. Consequently, his occupational identity cannot be compressed into the stock image of the 'beggar character'. His schedule of the crossroads is an objective product of his labour: recording the times of the early train, the market bus, the boat and the hospital vehicle is a public service, and its informal character does not cancel its social usefulness.

The Sequence of Events: Gradually Clarifying the Source of “Dead”

The first event is that the service gate remains closed and Fakira must rejoin the queue. The second is the guard's demand for an unreceipted 'facilitation fee', a demand which Fakira himself refrains from immediately labelling a proved act of corruption. The third change comes when, at the service window, he receives a written slip reporting that his original travel authorisation is inactive and that the linked life account identifies him as 'dead'. The fourth event is his experience of the alternative river route's actual distance, waiting time and risks. The fifth is Hira Mallah's agreement to testify only to journeys he has personally witnessed, coupled with his reduction of the boat's load after measuring the water's depth. The sixth is a written complaint, prepared with Naira, separating four different issues and the receipt of a provisional inquiry slip. The seventh is the addition of a cautious travel notice to the public schedule at the crossroads. At the end of all this, Fakira's status as dead has not been corrected, but a hearing date and an official's name have been obtained.

An essential distinction is that Chapter 1 established only that Fakira's pass had been blocked. In Chapter 3, the clerk supplies a definite ground: he is listed as dead in a life account. That is new information, and the reader's knowledge of the formerly ambiguous gate dispute genuinely grows. Nevertheless, the numbers on Sarita's death notice and Fakira's travel register differ; there is still no basis for regarding the two incidents as the outcome of a single conspiracy. Naira's notes keep this unproven connection clear. More importantly, Fakira has not read the word 'dead' with his own eyes; his knowledge comes from the employee's reading aloud and the slip subsequently handed to him. When the medium of testimony changes, the nature of confidence changes too, and the characters do not treat it as infallible firsthand observation.

A Narratology of Time: Clocks, Feet, Fares and Waiting

The title 'Time at the Crossroads' does not refer to an abstract count of hours. For Fakira, missing the midday train may mean losing five coins; a long detour means pain in his knee; a delay in delivering medicine to an elderly woman poses a health risk; for a fish seller, waiting for the boat may lower the market price. The same hour has unequal consequences for different social bodies. Narrative time is organised not merely by the sequence morning–afternoon–evening, but by the pressures imposed by each occupation's pace. Fakira's question—how much longer will the roundabout route take?—collides with the clerk's 'I don't know', exposing the administrative meaning of an 'alternative route'. Availability and equal practical utility are different conditions.

In a Genette-inspired examination of narrative duration, the chapter consists of many brief scenes: tea stall, guard, service window, boat landing and complaints office. Yesterday's loss of earnings and the pain in the knee appear as compressed analepses; the day's forward movement repeatedly pauses amid continuing dialogue. These pauses do not mean that 'nothing happened'. Asking for a receipt for money, demanding that a name be read aloud, and deciding to lessen the load on a boat each change the conditions of what can happen next. Narrative eventfulness should therefore not be calculated simply by counting the single appearance of the word 'dead'.

Focalisation and Embodied Knowledge: Hearing and Measuring

Fakira's walking stick, his recognition of places through sound, the warmth of a tea glass and a boat's slippery timber are means of embodied knowledge within the narrative. Yet the narrator does not make him an all-knowing hero of hearing. Fakira listens to what the employee says, and also asks for a written copy; Hira Mallah has authority over the safe depth for navigation by virtue of the measurements he has made in practice. Hira

dips a bamboo pole at three points, reduces the load because the current has changed, and intends to check the old paint marking again the following day. In the knowledge-system of this scene, direct perception is not a matter of eyes alone: it is a joint examination by a trained body and an instrument open to correction. Hira's reply, 'Being old doesn't make it right', establishes an arresting critical difference between tradition and present verification.

Fakira himself says that he cannot read the screen shown to him; the words read out to him have the status of information heard from another person. This is an exact admission of the difference between kinds of knowledge. When explaining the way to the river landing, Fakira acknowledges the need to learn from the bodily circumstances of others—the wet steps and the difficulty of descending while holding someone's hand. The novel therefore does not stage a simple competition between sight and hearing. The embodied skill of one person is repeatedly revised by another person's experience.

The Ethics of Evidence, Consent and Shared Testimony

Hira's proposal is particularly important: he will testify to Fakira's journeys on the days when he himself saw them, but will not swear to the days he did not see. The witness himself establishes the limits of the world of his experience. Fakira's complaint similarly distinguishes the guard's demand from any presumed motive behind that demand. The notation 'verification of the original entry pending' on the slip amounts to a written acknowledgement of uncertainty within the state's own records. This is not conclusive proof, judicially or philosophically; it is, however, a more responsible public record than an unequivocal accusation without verification.

Collectivity among these characters does not constitute a simple heroism. Hira promises to record the boat's times, not to fix market prices. Fakira suggests that people waiting at the landing keep a shared account, but not that the time needed to inspect the boat for safety should be reduced. Each works within the limits of his or her competence and authority. From this emerges one useful perspective of Videha Parallel History: public history belongs not only to the owners and employees named in registers, but also to a traveller's lost earnings, a boatman's measurements, an elderly person's medicine and the risks borne by bodies. Recording these things, however, is not a declaration of boundless sympathy; it is the work of asking questions and verifying them.

Narrative Achievement and Critical Limits

At the end of the chapter Fakira pays for his tea and straightens the transport timetable. The 'receipt for writing someone dead' and the continuing fares required for living bring the original paradox out of the home and onto the concrete ground of civic mobility. Fakira does not decide to abandon his livelihood while awaiting the correction of a record. The narration does not make him an inert object of pity; it holds together his work, humour, pain, reasoning and limited success.

Its limitation is that, amid all these events, the characters repeatedly practise an exceptionally high standard of evidentiary caution. The employee eventually supplies a written slip; the boatman defines the bounds of his observation; Fakira holds back an accusation; Naira records that the connection remains unproved. This discipline constructs the model the narrative wishes to offer. But it also risks diminishing the disorderly presence of actual social violence, impatience and confusion. The critical conclusion is not simply that the chapter is 'unbelievable', but that the room granted to thoughtful social reasoning ought also to be available to unexpected and unfinished human responses.

Chapter 4 — The River's First Home

Intertextuality across Two Times: From Satyavati's Boat to Tilwaha Ghat

For the first time the fourth chapter enters explicitly into the period of ancient Hastinapura. At a landing on the Yamuna, Satyavati opens and inspects a basket of fish; beneath a heap that looks fresh from above, she finds two spoilt fish. The scene plants the novel's concern with evidence in an ancient narrative. The price of raw fish ought to be determined by its actual condition, not merely by its sheen: this is a practical rule of a working household, not a quotation from a classical treatise. Satyavati's father accounts for the repair of nets, the boatman's share, transport and grain; Satyavati insists that the share due for the labour performed by her brother be recorded under his name. Before it becomes a story of the rise of kings and dynasties, the ancient epic narrative here becomes a scene of river economics and household obligations.

The familiar Satyavati–Shantanu story opens, in this transformation, through questions of attraction, conditions of marriage, rights of sons and humiliation. Satyavati does not regard entry into the royal household as liberation in itself. Her father does not treat his daughter as an object to be awarded, although proximity to political power weighs heavily upon his decisions. Satyavati asks whether she will have to conceal the earlier

identity of her boatman's family after marriage, whether her children's rights will be bargained away without her consent, and in whose account the boat workers' share of earnings will remain. These conditions reveal the internal complexity of the ancient character; she cannot be read solely as an instrument in dynastic politics.

Sequence of Events and the Clear Boundaries of the Two Temporal Strands

In the ancient sequence, the first event is Satyavati's examination of labour and naming of the work involved in the nets. The second is the development of disagreement between father and daughter about the meaning of the marriage proposal. The third is Devavrata's arrival and the placing before him of the condition concerning succession. The fourth is Satyavati's direct demand: room for her own voice, no deceit regarding her children's future, and no humiliation of the river family. A necessary limit must be observed here: the chapter foreshadows the consequences of the severe vow Devavrata will later make, but the passage does not actually depict that vow being formally pronounced. Knowledge of the future is the narrator's prolepsis, not an action already completed in the present of the story.

The modern sequence begins with an explicit indication of place and time: Videhapur, Ashadh 2039. Naira goes to the landing to measure the time and practical usability of Fakira's alternative route. Urmila speaks of washing for the hospital, separating different sorts of clothes, the additional time required to carry them up to a vehicle, and the absence of wages for that labour. The need to conceal patients' names comes to the fore when photographs for public circulation are proposed. Amina records the food account separately from Hasan's wages; Zubaida levels the wet earth. Notice of the annual observance honouring the ghat becomes a question of rights and timings; Chetan and Dev distinguish the performance of a song from its commercial exploitation. Phoolchan constructs an immediately usable safe path without claiming it as landownership. Bina separately records her shop earnings and inherited capital; Nahid declines to display her family's papers. Finally, Naira records an existing enclosure, unverified ownership and obstructed public access as three separate archival conditions.

The last change in the modern section is not simply that the 'measurement of the river landing' has been completed. Naira understands that a map showing a paved stairway or empty ground does not sufficiently describe actual use. Returning to Sarita, she says that the water and the way are not the same for everyone. Sarita's question—who will measure the land?—lays the ground for the next collective dispute. A river current does not restore

an old path merely by flowing; similarly, Naira's preparation of a document does not itself reopen the physical outlet. The separation between knowledge and implementation becomes a subject of the narrative.

Narratology of the Two-Time Structure

No reincarnation of a character, transfer of memory or invisible miracle is presented between the ancient and modern sections. The narrator effects a clear change in time and location from one strand to the other. What connects them is not merely a lineage name, but the river, the accounting of labour, women's consent, public rights of way and the measurement of entitlements. Satyavati's father keeps an account of the share due to those who propel the boat; modern Urmila claims wages for the extra time spent carrying washing. Satyavati demands that the worker's name be recorded; Amina writes down the price of food separately from the labour of carrying supplies. The comparison is meaningful insofar as the question 'whose work will be counted?' arises in unlike circumstances. It does not follow that the situations must be regarded as historically identical or continuous.

An important feature of the handling of time is that the ancient passage gives a broad indication of the eventual consequences of Devavrata's future vow, while the modern passage supplies a specific year, 2039. This juxtaposition allows the critic to examine two different narrative relationships. In the ancient section, tension arises from the reader's prior knowledge of epic events; in the modern section, unanswered questions from the first three chapters acquire a place-specific point of contact. Satyavati's story may be a morally anticipatory echo, but it is not the cause of the novel's modern events. To establish an unnecessary causal link between them would harm both the intertextual relation and the investigation of events.

The River's Materiality: Geography Is Not Merely a Symbol

There are paved steps at the river landing, but Urmila cannot wash there; a vehicle cannot descend to the place where she actually works. In a place described as public, hours of access, occupational equipment, the weight carried by the body, personal risks and collective rules differ. A short distance on paper may be impossible in practice. Through the contrast between the formal provision of 'alternative access' and the physical cost of 'actual access', the chapter reconnects with Fakira's experience at the railway gate. The author nevertheless cautions that a railway entrance and a river landing are not one institution: observing a partly shared problem does not authorise a single explanation for both cases. Such sensitivity to place is important for environmental narratology.

To read the river's current solely as a metaphor for women's identity or collective memory would be tempting but incomplete. A shifted landing, wet soil, the carriage of sheets, boatmen's safety, damage to nets and the risks to children descending to the water are material circumstances that determine narrative decisions. The river is an active environmental condition in the fictional world, not merely an aesthetic substance that dissolves human speech into metaphor. Naira's measurements do not remove the water; the distance between knowledge on paper and change on the ground establishes a structural sense of realism in the narrative.

Women's Voices, the Value of Labour and Distinct Decisions about Privacy

Chapter 4 does not reduce women to an undifferentiated category of 'victim'. Satyavati's question is her right to speak within the structures of lineage and marriage. Urmila's concerns are additional hours of washing-related labour and the use of the river landing. Amina decides to enter Hasan's payment separately from the food bill; Bina separates her earnings from family capital; Nahid does not immediately open her private papers to an investigator. These characters do not share a single aim in their social lives. The types of rights they claim, their economies and the timing of their decisions differ. The novel's broader claim to social inclusiveness can begin to be tested against this material; it cannot be conclusively established by it alone.

The question of consent returns effectively in three places. Urmila refuses to allow the photographing of clothes carrying hospital patients' names. Dev distinguishes the right to hear a song from the right to sell a recording of it. Nahid does not show Naira the private bag of papers, and Naira does not attempt to obtain it. This reveals a limit to the collection of community history: public recognition of labour is necessary, but such recognition does not make unauthorised consumption of personal information, creative work or documents justifiable.

Intertextual Propriety and the Critical Counterargument

The repositioning of Satyavati is a significant literary experiment: a decisive episode in the history of a royal lineage begins with river baskets, knots in fishing nets and an account of wages. Seeing an epic figure articulate rights in a strongly modern idiom inevitably raises questions of anachronism. As a 'modern rereading of ancient time', the work has scope for such transformation, but that description alone does not settle questions of artistic verisimilitude. At several points Satyavati's dialogue resembles contemporary rights discourse. The extent to which this produces a creative tension with other social and affective structures of ancient time will need to be examined in the classical episodes that follow.

The modern part presents, in one afternoon at the ghat, a particularly dense series of episodes involving washerwomen, a food seller, a genealogical singer, a songwriter, a farmer, a shopkeeper and a woman connected with inherited land. This multiplicity widens the social view, but another occupational example enters before the reader's relation with each person has grown deep. There is a potential tension between 'the complete presence of society' and 'the artistic depth of character'. The final assessment of Chapter 4 depends on whether, in later narrative divisions, these characters gain independent choices, mistakes, altered relationships and consequences in the plot, or remain merely social entries. The first four chapters provide enough evidence to pose the question, but not to answer it conclusively.

Comparative Conclusions on the First Four Chapters of the Adi Parva

From Records to Places: An Evolving Path of Inquiry

Chapter 1 begins with the contradiction between the living Sarita and the government's record of her death. Chapter 2 establishes ethical limits on the protection and disclosure of a private list of names. Chapter 3 turns Fakira's recorded status as 'dead' and the obstruction of his livelihood into concrete travel time. Through the ancient boat on the Yamuna and the modern landing at Tilwaha, Chapter 4 shows that measurements on paper and the conditions governing use in life are not the same. The sequence does more than expand a mystery of events: it creates four levels of inquiry into the authority of knowledge—the living presence of a person, consent to the use of names, public mobility and the material arrangement of workplaces. At every level, previously acquired information proves incomplete but not worthless.

It would be premature to settle definitively upon the novel's recurring objects as a 'system of symbols'. Rice, the pot, a prescription, a phone, a receipt, a train whistle, a walking stick, a boat, bamboo, an enclosure, clothes and an old ledger all perform practical work in different chapters. Recurrence becomes significant when an object plays a changed role amid a new character, difficulty or decision. For instance, rice in Chapter 1 is the immediate duty of a mother's living day; in Chapter 2, through the threat to extinguish the stove, it becomes a risk to livelihood; in Chapter 4, a moment of shared food without photographs humanly expands the recognition of labour's value and reciprocal obligation. Here there is a real pattern of recurrence, but not every mention of rice carries the same symbolic meaning.

Credibility and the Other Side of Criticism

The positive feature of the first four chapters is their narrative power, arising from the limits of evidence. Sarita, Naira, Fakira, Hira, Urmila and Satyavati each assert authority over their own decisions. Reducing the boat's load, dating a decision to keep a page closed, obtaining an acknowledgement of an application, and measuring the additional labour required at the river landing all change real situations. The novel's philosophical tendency can consequently take the form of social practice rather than remaining purely expository.

The countervailing weakness is already present. The characters' caution is often expressed in the same standard vocabulary: 'what was seen is separate', 'what was heard is separate', 'consent', 'no accusation without evidence'. At times the clarity of ethical procedure outweighs differences among characters. Bringing numerous occupations to the ghat in a single sequence yields an introductory sense of social comprehensiveness, but may diminish the untidiness of unplanned conflicts in life. The next stage of criticism must ask how much independent room the narrator gives to disagreement, ignorance, deceit, dissent, error and transformation in opposition to the story's instructive discipline. The text available here does not warrant a premature verdict on the triumph or failure of all 216 chapters.

Questions for Further Examination at the End of the First Four Chapters

Chapter 5 — Janaka's Measure

Setting and time: the royal residence in Mithila during Janaka's age, followed by Barki Pond and the approach to the river landing at Videhapur, in Ashadh 2039. Central question: can ownership, use of a route and the actual cost of labour all be expressed by the same measured line?

The Actual Sequence of Events: Two Different Worlds of Measured Lines

The chapter opens with the foundation of new construction in the rear courtyard of the royal residence. Wet stakes, a measuring cord and water collected in a trench establish the practical conditions of building work. While passing along the garden path, Sita sees that an old footpath is being enclosed. The chief builder invokes the state's ownership; a junior artisan reports that the gardeners' route to the well has been blocked. Sita gives him another opportunity to speak, and he explains the unpaid wages and the exclusion of workers from the decision. After Janaka arrives, Sita's question reaches beyond the donation of land to the pre-existing right of use. Janaka orders that the footpath be measured with a second cord and that the land's actual use be investigated before any donation. This is not final approval of the gift; it is an initial correction to the procedure for hearing the dispute. An elderly woman who sorts building stones identifies a cracked stone. The material is set aside, but the accounting for the loss remains outstanding. A date is fixed to open the wages ledger; payment is not made immediately.

In the eighteenth textual passage, the narration makes an explicit transition in time and place: "Videhapur, Ashadh 2039." Two proposed chalk lines lie across the footpath beside Barki Pond; they do not constitute a completed acquisition. Three distinct kinds of evidence concerning use and loss emerge: Kiran Raut's sharecropping, a consignment of seed and the additional turns required by a handcart; Ratan Bhuiyan's bills from an old contract and an uncertain debt; and the turning space needed for Urmila's cart of laundry. Naira does not claim to be an authorised municipal surveyor. When the surveyor arrives, a narrow drainage trench proves to be absent from the map, and the first stake is found to have been set on the wrong side. The stake is corrected and the old chalk line crossed out. But the disputes concerning Kiran's sharecropping, Ratan's liabilities and occupation of the land all remain undecided.

In its final movement, a public lesson at the school, poetic names associated with Janaka's era, a child's questions and Sarita's household ledger return the narrative to a domestic room. Naira keeps the poetic use

of the names "Triyuga" and "Lakshmana" distinct from the geography of the modern Tilwaha. At home, Sarita raises the next question arising from the public survey: how many names in the "old household tables" belong to family members, and how many to workers? The private page bearing twenty-seven names is still not opened. They agree to examine another ledger in daylight the next day. The chapter's resolution, then, is the correction of a technical error on the ground; its narrative consequence is the opening of another inquiry into records.

Narrative Time, Focalisation and Intertextuality across Two Ages

The chapter's first seventeen textual passages belong to ancient Mithila, and its remaining twenty-seven to modern Videhapur. These numbers describe the arrangement of passages, not an equal division of story time. The ancient section appears confined to a single occasion of inspecting construction. The modern section follows movement among several places over one day, from the morning survey to the evening meal. The transition from the seventeenth to the eighteenth passage is not a conventional return from a flashback; it is a marked cut between two temporal strands belonging to different fictional worlds. The ancient episode is not the historical cause of the modern survey team's actions. It is more reasonable to regard it as a meaningful parallel.

The narrator remains in the third person, revealing certain limits of circumstance and of the characters' inner responses. Sita's questions and Janaka's reaction dominate the ancient section; Naira's distinctions among what she has seen, heard and written, along with her hesitation, become the principal filter of knowledge in the modern section. Yet the narrative is not everywhere a direct transcript of "what Naira saw." It gives the pencil held by Kiran's daughter, Ratan's recollection of an earlier monsoon and the teacher's conversation with a child their own verbal vitality. This is shifting, partial focalisation within third-person narration; uninterrupted omniscience and complete entry into every consciousness are not demonstrated.

The combined framework of the Mahabharata and Ramayana does not posit the reincarnation of epic characters. The contemporary issue within Sita's conversation with Janaka is the tension between the generosity of a land donation and the earlier entitlements of its users. Modern Kiran's question, "Convenience for whom, and at whose expense?", is an ethical echo—not a word-for-word equivalent—of Sita's "Who will bear the burden of giving it up?" The ancient order of Janaka and the modern surveyor's correction become comparable only if their limits are remembered. In the first system, a king's word initiates decisive administrative action; in the modern one, an authorised measurement, receipts, proposals and claims from several parties constitute separate

procedures. To call the two "the same judicial system" would be anachronistic.

Testing Evidence: The Distinct Domains of Ownership, Use, Debt and Consent

From a narratological standpoint, the essential test of the chapter's reasoning is: "What exactly does each item prove?" A measuring tape and chalk line help inspect a possible width and boundary, but not automatically the real costs borne by users. Kiran's ledger documents cultivation expenses and the division of the sharecrop; it is not evidence of land ownership. Ratan's two bills include quantities of materials, sums due, stamps and unclear signatures. To infer from "an amount of debt is written down" that "the debt was actually contracted" would be faulty reasoning. Naira's words, "The hearing is not in my hands," make the division of responsibility between assisting an inquiry and deciding it institutionally explicit.

The correction of the visible line when the surveyor's first stake proves misplaced is a textual moment in which direct observation and the revision of an earlier documentary claim occur together. The paper had appeared correct, but an error in the starting point had compromised its applicability. The logical sequence has three parts: a sound measuring tape, an incorrect starting point and a corrected stake. The inference "the instrument is correct, therefore the result is correct" is thus blocked. Even so, a corrected boundary cannot by itself settle the dispute over occupation or debt. Refuting one error does not establish the justice of the entire administrative process: this is an important instance of the novel's epistemic restraint.

Rather than disclose her entire household debt account, Kiran makes the release of a copy conditional upon concealing the amounts. Ratan stops an attempt to photograph two different bills together, because the juxtaposition might misleadingly imply his acceptance of both. "A document is available" and "permission has been given to circulate it" are separate questions. It is improper to presume that showing a page entails agreement to every future use of it. Naira incorporates this limit into the way she works.

Time, Place and Social Burden: Beyond the Figures on a Line

The foundation at the royal residence, the turn beside the pond, the drainage pit, Urmila's handcart and the school veranda are different sites, but at none of them is a "way" merely a geometrical line. The gardeners' water pots, four sacks of seed, the washerwomen's clothes and children's journeys to school add different speeds, risks and costs to a footpath.

Figures for width and distance cannot measure the whole of lived experience. Kiran's daughter's drawing of a square field brings humour and an educational possibility to this tension; it is not a rejection of mathematics but a recognition of its limits.

A variety of community names—Bela Turha, Hema Dev, Rachna Dhimal, a proposal involving the songs of the Bhats, and Karun Damai's musical instrument—enter the survey papers. These are not yet complete life narratives; some people are still present only through slips of paper. It would be a critical error to treat them as identical kinds of "victims." The repair of an instrument and the fee for its performance, permission to record sound, the school roll and the market's weekly charge involve distinct economic and ethical relations. The critical standpoint of Videha Parallel History asks how labour and use omitted from documents of public development might be recorded. It cannot, however, classify every slip as the same kind of property claim.

Achievements, Language and the Uncomfortable Counterargument

The chapter's effective artistic decision is to present the correction of the survey as a limited outcome. Moving the stake is a real physical event: space is found earlier for Urmila's cart to turn, and the surveyor corrects the line. Yet the social disputes continue unchanged afterwards. The story does not announce an impossible, instant justice. Likewise, when the elderly stone-sorting woman's experience leads to the removal of defective material from construction, the outstanding question of payment sustains the duality between practical knowledge of things and economic responsibility.

A first limitation is that the dialogue of the Janaka-era characters carries the linguistic tone of modern questions about administrative justice with unusual clarity. This critical transparency may help a new reader, but it lessens the sensuous distance of ancient time. A second limitation is that, although the modern sequence mentions papers belonging to many occupational communities within one day, their mutual conflicts and embodied private lives have not yet developed fully. Third, the discipline of saying "this is evidence of one thing, not of another" repeatedly appears in the narrator's explanatory sentences. Allowing the scene itself to invite judgment in some places could increase suggestiveness and the reader's participation. Nevertheless, Kiran's humour, the movement of Urmila's cart and the domestic sound of Sarita's grinding stone give warmth to the austerity of the critical vocabulary.

Chapter conclusion. "Janaka's Measure" is best read not as a tale in which the land-acquisition dispute is decided, but as a story about the evidentiary limits of the instruments used to mark a boundary. The line is corrected;

not every outstanding obligation in people's lives is discharged. From Janaka's time to 2039, the central intertextual proposition is that bodily experience of use must still be heard alongside claims of ownership, although the institutional form through which that happens is not the same.

Chapter 6 — The Household Tables

Setting and time: from Sarita's home to Rajinar and the school veranda, from the morning after the preceding chapter until evening. Central question: how are ledger entries, dates of inscription, oral memory and permission to use private pages to be distinguished within the single word "record"?

Opening the Household Ledger: The History of an Object and of Its Inscription Are Different

At the end of Chapter 5, Sarita had offered to show the ledger in daylight; Chapter 6 fulfils that promise. Before the rice is placed on the stove, a bag is brought out from beneath the low wooden seat. Sarita carefully eases off the thread binding the bundle instead of cutting it. This material care does not merely honour the document's age: it is also a domestic practice of avoiding damage to ownership and context. The cover reads "Household Tables." There are columns for rice, oil, salt, medicine and travel fares, and a partially preserved old school stamp on the reverse: clear evidence that old paper has been reused. Sarita explains that the age of a stamp does not establish that the subsequent writing was made on the same date.

A page marked 2027, "credit" written in red and "settled" in blue, a well-repair receipt from 2038 and lines recording expenditure at Rajinar all appear in the same ledger. But the sequence of ink colours cannot establish the dates of inscription. Sarita says that, on occasion, she used red to enter a new amount when the blue pen had dried up. The household spent money on bricks for the well and a rope to draw water, but an empty column does not answer whether the money was repaid. The actual expense of domestic assistance is not identical to a liability recorded in a public account.

Sarita allows the copying of two pages, not the entire ledger. A significant new fact concerns the sheet of twenty-seven names: it was not a list completed in a single sitting. Sometimes Sarita wrote down a name she had heard; sometimes she corrected an earlier account. In four places, the presence of different ink leaves the questions of who wrote the entries and when still unresolved. Naira records the date on which this oral testimony

is given, without conflating the copy, the original page and Sarita's recollection.

A second cluster of events takes place at Rajinar. Lalit Mallik notices the physical danger posed by a loose railing and worn bricks; Padma checks whether the warning can be read from the position where it is needed. Sudha Rai proposes to pay for a public shelter and donate land, but a new line on the plan blocks two tenant families' access to the well. A hearing on usage is proposed, while the donation remains a deferred decision. Separate repair bills, fees for songs and musical performances, supply receipts, advances for wedding materials and an envelope containing a private letter make a public accounting possible, but ownership and purpose are kept distinct. A temporary rope is placed near the loose railing; this is not a completed repair.

By evening, a decision has been made to seek fresh permission to use Sarita's old expense records for a specific purpose. At Sarita's insistence, Naira changes "payment unverified" in her notes to "repayment unverified." The final scene connects the blurred year numerals on an old wooden seat, schoolchildren's differing accounts of their grandparents and the simple expectation of adding another handful of rice to the pot at home. This extra serving prepares for Shakuntala and her granddaughter's arrival in the next chapter; it should not retrospectively be treated as dramatic evidence of an invented mystery.

A Threefold Examination of Inscription Time, Record Time and Narrative Time

The chapter brings together a sheet carrying an old school stamp, accounts for 2027, a repair receipt from 2038 and the present reading session of 2039. It would be wrong to dismiss such coexistence as "necessarily a flashback." Past events are not re-enacted as scenes by the narrator; the present characters read old pages and test their chronology. Here the past is not only a directly narrated scene but also the subject of documents and memory. At least four temporal levels must be separated: when the paper was produced, when the entry was written, when the event or expense occurred, and when it is read in 2039. These levels do not necessarily coincide.

In terms of narrative pace, the turning of pages in the household ledger forms an extended scene. The numerous occupational slips at Rajinar are presented in comparatively rapid succession; the evening kitchen slows the rhythm again. The chapter's distribution of duration thus uses domestic pauses at its beginning and end to hold the complexity of its central public sequence. The narrator principally distributes knowledge around Naira and Sarita; Sudha's hesitation, Padma's decision and Lalit's restraint about

measurement can also be read from the scenes. The aim is not to disclose the inner minds of all characters everywhere. Naira's revision of what she has written is an operative sign of character development: she does not merely collect information; she changes her own first formulation.

Evidence and Narration: Ink Colour Cannot Prove a Date, and an Empty Column Cannot Prove a Debt

The attempt to fix an inscription's date from the colour of its ink exposes an inference without sufficient invariable connection. Different inks can be used on different days, and the same ink can be used on many days; there is no certain correlation between colour and date. Similarly, Sarita's old receipt records an expense, but the repayment column is empty. That absence proves neither that "the amount was settled" nor that it "must still be outstanding." Sarita's correction to "repayment unverified" is noteworthy because the terminology used in an inquiry can itself change the limits of what the event is taken to establish.

The owner's limited permission is not merely a general declaration of confidentiality. Sarita specifies: show these two pages, for this particular purpose, not the family's entire account of medicines and meals. Naira returns the original ledger. At Rajinar, Lalit again requests authorisation for a particular use; consent to make the first copy does not automatically authorise every subsequent application. Such conduct becomes the ethical process through which knowledge is acquired in the story. The authenticity of a private page, its suitability for public use and permission to circulate it are three distinct tests.

The well water looks bright, but brightness does not establish potability. Lalit refuses to state its depth without a safe measurement. A temporary rope does not mean that the repair has been completed. These three small examples are not slogans repeating one philosophical term, but different occasions for practical restraint in knowledge: perception of a quality, measurement of a quantity and determination of the stage a task has reached. Water must be available to quench the granddaughter's thirst, but removing the child from the loose railing is an immediate physical obligation. The scene brings the chapter's philosophical concerns and its worldly urgency together.

Donation and Entitlement: From Ancient Janaka to Modern Sudha

In Chapter 5, Sita had asked what happens to earlier users' rights when land is given away. In Chapter 6, Sudha Rai offers to pay for a shelter, but the line on the plan cuts across tenant families' route to the well. Sudha's generosity is not simple villainy; her willingness to bear the cost is genuine. So are the tenants' labour and the weight of the water pots they

carry. Padma points out the route past a pit and broken bricks, easily called "another path" on paper but difficult in practice. A hearing date is proposed; a generous act does not erase the challenge raised by private ownership. In the sequence of these two chapters, epic intertextuality becomes a fresh examination of contemporary social transactions.

The Indian poetics of propriety—auchitya—raises a question here: the moral sentiment attached to a gift cannot be praised independently of the way its consequences operate in society. Criticism holds back the habitual epithet "great donor" until evidence of actual use on the ground has been assembled. This does not, however, make the ethics of fictional action completely equivalent to classical theories of charitable giving. The text itself defers the donation, and the critic therefore has no authority to pronounce a final judgment.

Labour Slips, Multiple Voices and the Evidence of Children

The accounting room at Rajinar reveals the distortion involved in treating boat timber, the well railing, repairs to a musical instrument, fees for folk songs, wedding materials, shop supplies and household medicine as a single undifferentiated "community expense." Padma resists the tendency to ask performers to dance and sing without payment in the name of "public contribution." Lakshmi Kathbaniya distinguishes a supplier's bill from the mistake of entering it against a committee debt. Shanti Bari separates an advance for wedding materials from public donations. This is not mere decoration through social categories; the classification of accounts is a concrete question. Nevertheless, the depth of the personal lives available to us for Phoolmati, Ramesh, Lakshmi and Shanti remains limited to different degrees within this chapter.

The child's thirst and the old school seat provide two different emotional pivots. The first restores an immediate bodily need amid extended discussion of costs. The second—who made the old seat, and what do its numerals mean?—suspends any conclusion and prepares a sequence about memory in the following chapter. The children say, "Grandfather always tells one story," while "Grandmother tells it differently." Their disagreement raises a question: is repeated remembrance sufficient evidence of truth? The novel does not instantly attribute dissenting memories to dishonesty. It is a meaningful opening into the multigenerational narration to come.

Language, Artistic Achievements and the Examination of Limits

The title "Household Tables" is not merely a reference to an arithmetical exercise, but to a mixed register of domestic income and expenditure, school papers, memories and the counting involved in stories. Sarita's

remark, "The colour of a pen is not a clock," establishes an argument through a domestic image, without burdening it with technical philosophical terminology. At the end, the remaining rice, the extra guest's plate and Sarita's "another handful for two people's rice" deepen the story's emotional contact. The accounting of rice is not only an ordinary calculation of costs; it also holds out the possibility of eating together in the future.

Yet the sequential introduction of many bills and slips in the middle of the chapter risks making the reader's time resemble an administrative list. Each document teaches a useful distinction between categories, but the characters do not all receive comparable depth of psychological risk. A further question is that almost every character identifies errors of evidence with great alertness; human mistakes, self-interest, confusion or half-resolved conflict receive less room. Later chapters may alter this preliminary assessment. Sudha's hesitation, Sarita's incomplete memory and the child's immediate thirst partly interrupt the uniform instructional tone.

Chapter conclusion. Here the domestic archive is not a miniature version of history but an active means of struggling with history's uncertainty. Some pages of the ledger have been opened, not all; expenditure is established, repayment is not; the danger at the well is temporarily contained, but the repair is incomplete. The clear presentation of these incompletions strengthens the chapter's credibility.

Chapter 7 — The Bench of Five Generations

Setting and time: an evening at Sarita's home, with Shakuntala arriving from Kumhrauti; five temporal segments present within the house—1942, 1974, 1993, 2008 and 2027—and a separate remembered account of the pond excavation of 1939. Central question: should family history be written under a single name of ownership, or related to the differing claims of generations, labour, remembrance and absence?

The Main Register of Events: Accounts of Five Times and One Unanswered Question

The extra rice at the end of Chapter 6 becomes a guest's meal in this chapter. Shakuntala comes to Sarita's home from Kumhrauti, bringing two samples of clay, old papers and her granddaughter. The granddaughter has been assigned a school exercise about the family home over five generations. She can write five names, but does not know who made an old bench at school. Naira has only a sketch of blurred numerals on the bench's leg. Shakuntala recounts what her father told her: that the bench

had been made by a woodworker in exchange for clay vessels. She herself specifies the limits of her evidence—she has heard her father's account but has not seen the original ledger.

After the meal, Sarita opens a separate bundle. It is not the "Household Tables" ledger of Chapter 6. Its first page bears the year 1942, but its account of an earlier generation was written down later from the oral recollections of Sarita's maternal grandmother. The story of the pond excavation in 1939 is likewise told on the basis of what she heard from that grandmother. Removing earth, carrying water, cooking and tending injured hands were all forms of labour in the excavation, but the labour register omitted the time spent by the woman who cooked the rice. A woman had brought an expense ledger and explained to the workers that cooking, too, was indispensable labour in a collective construction. Sarita cannot remember her name; the work does not supply an invented name to fill the absence.

Shakuntala shows samples of red and grey clay but refuses to determine their suitability without testing them on the potter's wheel. A construction enclosure has narrowed the old footpath to the clay source. Transport has become costlier, payment for pots remains overdue and the granddaughter's school admission expenses have stalled. Shakuntala does not claim the entire parcel of land as hers; she asks that the old access route be examined and a hearing held. Her granddaughter expresses a wish to learn pottery while also attending school, and Shakuntala promises that the child will be free to choose her future occupation.

The characters then read, in sequence, about a household move and unequal access to education in 1974, an emigrant's letter and uncertain delivery in 1993, school fees and incomplete distribution of textbooks in 2008, and Sanket's childhood drawing from 2027. At each point there are details that must prevent an easy transformation into myth: the "reached home" field is empty, which does not establish that the person disappeared; there is no signature confirming receipt of books, so distribution is unproven; and the blank area in the drawing may have resulted from torn paper, so an absent person's name must not be supplied by inference.

Further papers concern clay, transport, a moneylender's bill, a marriage register, payment for songs and a warehouse notice. Finally the granddaughter writes five dates, draws five houses and asks, "Are these five houses the same house?" Sarita replies that the land, rooms, people and arrangements for eating together have continued to change. The child agrees to label the account of the 1939 excavation separately as "heard." Shakuntala decides to request an examination of old access rights in a written application, not to assert total ancestral ownership. The final scene prepares the next chapter as Sarita puts aside a private letter bearing a postal

stamp from Simatirtha, addressed to Ramvati, and promises not to open it without permission.

Story Order and Narrative Order: Not Five Dramatized Times, but Five Times of Reading

The title "The Bench of Five Generations" might create an expectation of complete biographies of five generations, or five fully dramatised flashback scenes. The primary text does not construct such a sequence. The principal present-time story consists of a shared meal and the reading of documents over one evening. Events from 1942, 1974, 1993, 2008 and 2027 are recalled by the characters through old pages, signatures, a child's picture, family memories and letters. The narrator does not move directly into an earlier year in a scene that says, in effect, "We are now in 1974." For a Genette-inspired analysis of narrative time, it is therefore necessary to distinguish a date reference, a representation of memory and a full scenic analepsis.

The page dated "1942" is itself not an eyewitness account from 1942, because Sarita explains that the event narrated by her grandmother was written down later. The 1939 excavation, too, is known through a reported date that has yet to be checked against independent records. Adding this further line of the past complicates chronology instead of simplifying it. The physical age of a document, the period of its writer, the date of the purported occurrence and the child's reading today form four critical levels. Here "the past" is not a single solid compartment of time but a multiply narrated family reconstruction whose limits can be examined.

The present action runs from the beginning of the meal through the reading of documents and the rainfall to the guests' departure. At the end, Sanket's question about the remaining rice and a preference for chillies recalls the opening shared meal. It is not a literal repetition of the same scene but a circle of meaning: at first there are several different tastes within the household, and at the end the granddaughter's preference is sought. Through this small recurrence, the collective identity called "home" is formed without erasing individual choice.

Memory as Evidence: Neither Erase nor Invent the Missing Name

The name of the woman who cooked during the excavation is unknown. Two tempting critical errors follow: first, to treat her work as insignificant because her name is unavailable; second, to invent a name out of moral sympathy and thereby create a new, false historical fact. Sarita's words avoid both. She offers oral testimony to the social reality of the labour, while acknowledging the limit created by the absence of a particular worker's name. This procedure is especially significant from the standpoint of Videha Parallel History: neglected labour must be brought into history,

but filling missing records with fabricated details would destroy the credibility of a parallel history.

The illegibility of the numeral scratched into the old bench, the oral account from Shakuntala's father, the granddaughter's drawing, Sanket's torn paper, an empty "reached home" field and a missing signature for textbook distribution are not equivalent types of evidence. The mark on wood may be a visible trace of time, but does not identify the maker. The absence of a delivery confirmation does not prove that an emigrant severed relations. To claim that the blank space in Sanket's drawing depicts a "missing person" would be especially careless, since the artist himself allows for the possibility of torn paper. The story works to prevent such unwarranted inference.

The problem of evidence in this chapter also moves some distance beyond legal controversy. The taste of food at home, a grandmother's speech, the reality of a tap breaking on the day of an examination, and shared family laughter may suffice to establish the meaning of a life; they cannot simply stand in for judicial records. When Sarita says that the tap really had broken, but that "how often the truth was spoken on someone's behalf" is another table of calculation, the factual truth of an event and the purpose for which it is narrated emerge on separate levels. The existence of a true fact does not establish the complete impartiality of the telling.

Women's Labour, Autonomy between Generations and the Plural Home

The chapter's first "issue" is the school question, "Whose home is it?" The question seems to demand the name of an owner, but the answer expands to include those who cook, make earthenware, migrate to earn a living, study at night, meet domestic expenses, and belong to a family in different ways. "Whose name is on the papers?" and "Whose lives make the home?" are questions that cannot be entirely separated, yet cannot be made identical. The granddaughter draws five square houses; her uncertainty over whether they are "one house" becomes a visual metaphor for the story's central idea.

Shakuntala's granddaughter wants to learn the art of earthenware but also to attend school. Shakuntala makes clear that if the child chooses not to pursue the family trade, her education will not stop. This rejects a determinism based on caste, occupation and descent. Yet the outstanding payments for pots and the cost of school admission remain. The difference between a "right to choose" and the "material possibility of making a choice" is effective here. Shakuntala's assurance is admirable, but the work does not conceal its practical vulnerability when resources are insufficient.

The circumstances of learning letters at night within a household in 1974 and the small struggle to be excused from washing dishes on examination day in 2008 are not a complete history of women's education, but poignant evidence of how labour is divided within homes. Naira's memory and Sarita's acknowledgement do not create a uniform image of the "self-sacrificing mother"; they retain laughter, doubt and cooperation between mother and daughter. The grandmother's unpaid cooking during the 1939 excavation and the present debt owed for Shakuntala's pottery establish an interpretive relation between widely separated periods: the failure to count labour can become an impediment transmitted across generations. This remains a communal hypothesis about causes; a single page does not "prove" the unbroken inherited exploitation of any one family.

The Uses of Peripheral Papers: Community History versus Cataloguing

Amrita Chauhan's claim concerning a clay site and Gomti Beldar's hours of transport are not evidence for the same contention merely because they are tied in one bundle. Mahendra Mahaseth's old measurements and Binod Jaiswal's purchase receipt indicate different owners, dates and amounts due. Nilima Nurang seeks an amendment to the register of maternal names; Hamida Miriasin possesses rights concerning consent and remuneration for the use of a song; Shashi Mahuri's warehouse notice does not conclusively describe the contents of the warehouse. Each slip introduces a distinct discipline of community life and labour.

Yet this is also where the work's formal difficulty becomes visible. The appearance of many occupational slips during one evening meal demonstrates the ambition to make "the whole of society present," but at points transforms narrative coincidence into a planned catalogue. The potentially independent stories of Nilima, Hamida and Shashi remain brief statements; the reader cannot hear enough of the natural rise and fall of their individual speech. This limitation does not contradict the work's social inclusiveness. It is the unfinished artistic challenge of converting inclusion into a fully realised structure of characters.

Language, Rasa and the Final Judgment

From beginning to end, the chapter's objects are tangible: a clay lid, a damp notebook, wrapped papers, stove heat, red and grey clay, a broken wooden bench. Before readers understand these as metaphors, they encounter them as useful things in the characters' lives. Shakuntala's joke about the five different tastes at the meal becoming "five pieces of a house" produces a comic feeling. The gaps in the record of the rainfall and the granddaughter's incomplete answer convey not sentimental pity but

responsible curiosity. The diversity of emotional supports in the chapter is thereby enlarged.

A critical limitation remains: many characters repeatedly speak in unusually well-organised sentences warning against errors in evidence. Oral family histories are generally filled with forgetting, uncertainty, incapacity and interpersonal bitterness. Here several women immediately clarify what kind of proof cannot be accepted. At times this discipline seems to limit the development of distinct linguistic personalities. The granddaughter's drawing, Sanket's embarrassment and Sarita and Naira's exchange about the broken tap, however, soften the formality.

Chapter conclusion. The "five generations" of the title are not five steps towards archival certainty, but five different and incomplete points of entry into family history. The maker of the bench has not been identified; the memory of 1939 has not been verified; Shakuntala's claim to access has entered the process of a hearing; and a private letter has remained safe while awaiting its rightful owner. The history of lives becomes an art of writing questions, not a licence to erase empty spaces.

Chapter 8 — The Letter from Simatirtha

Setting and time: Sarita's home, the journey from Videhapur to the Makhaniya pool, the worksite at the pool and the return home. Because of Ramvati's letter, old family and migrant connections with Simatirtha enter the narrative. Central question: what kinds of problems of knowledge are created by variant recorded names, labour in aquatic cultivation, ownership of a private letter and uncertainty about the movement of water?

Two Independent Courses of Action on One Journey

The chapter begins with the protection of a damp envelope at Sarita's house. The letter belongs to Ramvati Khatwe, who had earlier left it in Sarita's keeping. Sarita has not opened it, and Naira prevents Sanket from photographing it. The aim is to return the letter to its owner, not to reveal its confidential contents. The vehicle heads towards the Makhaniya pool. Along the road, it encounters the transport of wool by Devaki Pal, Phoolo Chaurasia's betel-leaf fields, Suraj Chaudhary's daily wages from palm trees, and the bamboo pipes at Nandini Bhandari's nursery. Although the four activities share the risks of one route, their economic claims are not the same.

At the pool, Ramani Bind demonstrates the difference between dried seeds from the previous season and the new seed stock. Sowing in water, selecting the seeds, drying them and popping the kernels are separate

stages of work. The aquatic-cultivation register describes the women's work as "family assistance" and counts it as zero. Ramani presents their working hours, names recorded with consent for attendance, and separate receipts for women who want privacy. She is not demanding an immediate transfer of ownership of the lease; she asks that the value and rate of existing labour be recorded clearly. The accountant does not pay immediately, but gives written agreement to supply separate rates and copies of attendance records. Half the shelter is cleared for women to rest and change their wet clothes. These are two real immediate changes, one archival and the other physical.

At midday, Ramvati receives her letter. She first asks who has seen the envelope, then opens and reads it privately herself. Three layers of dispute emerge: an old relationship with her natal family, a variation in the form of her name in the marriage register, and a demand for proof in documents concerning remittances. Ramvati does not provide a full copy of the letter; she chooses to disclose only one necessary piece of information. A family term of address has been mistranslated into an administrative name, making a member of her natal family appear to belong to her marital family. Ramvati proposes correcting this through separate testimony from both sides. Naira does not fully archive her personal letter.

Meanwhile questions arise about Nasima and Rafiq's migrant earnings, the discrepancy in Amir Kulhaiya's calculations of fees, Sugni's memories of a Kosi flood, Kamla Jain's terms for an advance, and the market price of makhana. In Amir's account, the sums sent and received do not reconcile; the intermediary is not immediately called a thief. Sugni's recollection of the Kosi or Kosika is not treated as a measurement of the pool's present water level. Ramani leaves further negotiation open about separate prices, safety and written wage rates for makhana processing. At the end, the public board displays totals for workers, hours and sums due, while private names are protected. The title of a song is entered on a separate sheet with the singer's permission; Naira does not make a recording.

Before returning home, Ramani points out the difference between the reported direction of incoming water and what has actually been measured today. Tara and Aditi may come to examine it the next day: that is a proposed programme, not a completed hydrological test. Ramvati's letter has reached its owner, but the name correction is unfinished; a record of labour has been prepared, but wages have not been paid; Amir's fee calculations likewise remain unverified. The story returns home and pauses on the ordinary choice of rice and chillies.

The Journey of a Letter: Not Secret Plot Information but Respect for Ownership

In a conventional mystery, a character who obtains an old letter opens it, reads forbidden truths and accelerates a dramatic series of events. This chapter reverses the procedure: the characters do not open the letter or copy it; they find its owner and return it. The literary energy of the mystery arises not from an absence of curiosity but from voluntarily restraining it. Ramvati's first question—who has seen the letter?—is the plot's ethical centre. A private object does not automatically become the property of a public inquiry.

Ramvati reads the old letter in private. The reader is not given its verbatim contents; knowledge extends only as far as Ramvati chooses to share. This is deliberately constructed narrative under-information. It should be understood not as a failure of the narrator, but as a limit established by a character's right over information. A question remains, however: by repeating this restraint, does the work sometimes reduce the characters' inner conflict, the unexpected pain of private memories and the complex resonances of their relationships? Ramvati's refusal to condemn both her natal and marital families indiscriminately, and her insistence on retaining control over her own name, give this problem a degree of complexity.

The episode involving a translation error is particularly important to linguistic narratology. A familial form of address means different things in two languages, leading to an incorrect reading of the relationship. Translation here is not merely a change of language; it is a classification of relationships according to institutional categories. Ramvati is not only a victim of mistranslation: she decides whose testimony will be sought, how much she will disclose to whom, and whose names will not be made public. The conflict between the remembered maternal name and the marriage-register document may be read as a question of modern gendered autonomy. But the text does not offer an easy solution in which making "one name identical everywhere" ends the dispute between the two families.

The Technology and Labour of Makhana: The Many Actions Hidden within "Produce"

The Makhaniya pool is not merely a natural vista. Thorns, marshland, footpaths, older and newer consignments of seeds, times for selection, periods of drying, heat from a fire and the skill of popping kernels construct the narrative geography through a division of labour. Ramani makes clear that new seeds are still in the water. To call them a consignment already popped today would be false in respect both of the

market price and of daily wages. This material process becomes evidence for a social economy. Work performed within the water and work performed beside the fire require different periods and risks before they converge in the single commodity called "makhana."

The aquatic-cultivation register's entry of zero against "family assistance" creates a collision between labour that has occurred and its invisibility in the archive. Ramani's response is not an immediate demand to seize the property lease, but to record the recognition of work and the amount due in separate lines. Feminist labour studies and Videha Parallel History share an important question here: how can the work that makes production possible be recognised independently of ownership documents? The attendance sheet written by the women themselves is public testimony, but the text does not yet establish either its legal status or the final success of payment.

The division between individual receipts and the public board is distinctive. Some women do not want their names displayed publicly, even while their total working hours and payments due appear in shared accounts. Ramani's method handles the potential contradiction practically: permission to conceal names must not become an excuse for perpetuating unpaid labour. This is not simply a slogan of "women's rights." Written agreement, public figures for sums due, clearing the shelter and providing a resting area are concrete achievements of the characters. The absence of payment and the incomplete revision of rates remain equally explicit.

Water, Geography and the Discipline of Distinct Memories

The route in the chapter passes work associated with wool, betel leaves, palm trees and nurseries. All involve responses to climate, but they represent different productive relationships. Devaki's statement, "The fare is mine; the road belongs to everyone," concentrates the tension between shared geography and private expenditure. In managing the pool's water, Nandini's current measurements of a pipe must be rechecked if the rains change. Phoolo's field expenses should not be imposed on the pool's workers, and a separate route must be retained for animals. Such decisions reveal the ecological interdependence of rivers, ponds and livelihoods, but calling them all an indivisible "community" would erase inequalities of cost.

The old memory of a flood named Kosi or Kosika is not the present water level of the pool. The chapter's introductory technical description mentions "two-time intertextuality," but the primary chapter does not contain an entirely independent scenic age of epic action comparable to Janaka's time in Chapter 5. Here the past enters through the letter, family

recollection and an old disaster record. It is necessary to acknowledge this distinction. Similarity of names or suffering does not establish that the rivers, places, dates or offences are identical. Ramani's final question likewise begins an investigation into future measurements of water; the work does not assert that the mystery of the water has been proved.

Voice, Narrative Pause and Emotional Reflection

The chapter's conversations allow the possibility of distinct voices: Ramani's firmness, the accountant's procedural obstacles, Ramvati's selective disclosure, Amir's financial concern, Sarita's domestic laughter and the singer's ownership of a melody. Importantly, the accountant is not constructed only as an oppressive official. He explains an institutional constraint against disbursing money without an account from above. It would be wrong either to pronounce him morally innocent or instantly to cast him as a villain. Ramani recognises the constraint while pressing for written documentation of wages. There is a genuine dispute within this tension.

Thorns piercing hands, wet clothes, the water-surrounded marsh and kernels heated over a fire give the story embodied reality. Amid these, forgetting the tune of a song, Sarita losing the rhythm, laughter and a young woman deciding to practise after her examination move the narrative from an economic dispute into human leisure. To call this pause "a digression from the main story" would be inappropriate. A labouring woman's life is not confined to her working hours; she also has memories, songs and educational preferences. Separating the song sheet from the labour account is, however, another necessary distinction concerning linguistic and cultural ownership.

The final scene returns to the question of food at home. From Chapter 4 through Chapter 8, the narrative repeatedly returns from extensive social labour to the domestic kitchen. For now, the artistic justification of the recurrence is that even household meals are not an impersonal, universal kind of work. Asking about individual preference is an event that makes a relationship. Sarita does not assume Sanket's wish for chillies; she says that it should be asked. This recalls the final humorous exchange in Chapter 7.

Favourable and Unfavourable Evidence within the Text

The clearest achievement of the chapter is its distribution of real, small-scale outcomes. The letter reaches its rightful owner; Ramani makes written progress in the labour register; the women receive a place to rest; the public board records figures for the work; and the final question about water remains unanswered, giving direction to a future inquiry. Each achievement reaches a different degree of completion. The work does not

jump to unsupported conclusions that "the name has been corrected," "wages have been paid" or "the fault in the watercourse has been found."

Yet the sequential concentration of named occupations, fields, produce, a letter, another river and trading conditions puts pressure on the reader's sense of depth in the middle of the chapter. Many episodes end quickly with very careful definitions, something a rigorous critique may call an excess of instructional design. The scene involving songs partly loosens this tension, because the characters laugh, make mistakes, learn and freely choose when to attend. The further consequences of Ramani's wage rates, Ramvati's name correction, Amir's fee dispute and the final evidence of water testing remain matters for verification in later chapters. To assume their success now would be unwarranted.

Chapter conclusion. The actual central event of "The Letter from Simatirtha" is not the opening of a letter but its delivery to the proper person. The parallel story of labour makes the invisible time of women working in makhana production available for written recognition. The two strands do not place private consent and public responsibility in opposition; they test the different procedures appropriate to each.

Chapters 5–8: Comparative Narratological Conclusions

Measurement, Ledger, Bench and Letter: Four Objects, Four Questions

Chapter 5 corrects a chalk line; Chapter 6 corrects a false inference about dates from the household ledger; Chapter 7 resists treating five periods of family life as one uniform version of home; and Chapter 8 separates the ownership of a private letter from the recording of women's labour in production. The sequence moves from external space to domestic history, then along the path of a letter and into the economy of water-based cultivation. The four objects do not perform the same function. A survey plan is an instrument of a public proposal; a household ledger provides limited family evidence; the bench and papers raise questions of family memory; the letter carries a private relationship. It is not enough to place all of them under the general phrase "politics of documents." Their evidentiary validity, purposes, ownership and powers of decision are distinct.

In Chapter 5 the surveyor's incorrect starting point is corrected, but the dispute over rights remains unsettled. In Chapter 6 replacing "payment" with "repayment" improves verbal precision, without completing the financial account. In Chapter 7 the granddaughter's heading "heard" acknowledges the difference of source behind an uncertain memory of

1939, without discovering the maker of the bench. In Chapter 8 the definite act of returning the letter is completed, while the dispute over Ramvati's legal name continues. Thus the density of events at the opening of the novel is better assessed not by counting explosions, revelations and punishments, but by asking "What has actually changed in the condition of each object?"

The Sequence of Days and the Many Uses of the Past

In the principal modern storyline, Chapter 5 moves from measuring a proposed boundary to a promise to open the household ledger. Chapter 6 opens the ledger the next morning, and in the evening puts aside an extra serving for a guest. Chapter 7 starts with that guest's arrival and ends by setting aside a letter. Chapter 8 begins the journey to return that letter on the following morning. These transitions create a visible continuity of time. Within that continuity, however, ancient Janaka's era (Chapter 5), the non-contemporaneous entries in an old household ledger (Chapter 6), reported and written memories of 1939 and five other dates (Chapter 7), and the old Simatirtha letter and Kosi flood memory (Chapter 8) constitute different ways of representing the past. Collecting them under the single term "flashback" would obliterate essential differences in narrative technique.

The Sequence of Women's Rights over Evidence and over Labour

Sita calls for the old path to be measured; Naira distinguishes the limits of reported testimony and authorised measurement; Sarita permits inspection of two pages from her domestic ledger; Shakuntala requests a hearing over an old access route rather than inventing an absolute property claim; Ramvati opens her own letter; and Ramani objects to women's labour hours being entered as zero. To read every instance as one fixed form of "women's awakening" would erase specific social differences. One woman seeks access to land, another the correct meaning of a receipt, another privacy over a letter and yet another a wage rate. Their instruments and risks differ. Maintaining these distinctions is a necessary condition of feminist criticism.

Indian Poetics, the Examination of Evidence and Critical Restraint

From the perspective of dhvani, the corrected line, a handful of rice, an illegible bench and the safely returned letter generate unspoken social meanings; interpretation must nevertheless begin with the practical use of the original objects. From the perspective of auchitya, the public consequences of generous declarations by a king, donor or committee require examination. From the perspective of rasa, the work offers more than pathos: Kiran's humour about the field, Shakuntala's shared meal, the

granddaughter's questions, Ramani's song and Sarita's lapse in rhythm unsettle any uniform moral lesson. The questions of narration are these: who presents the evidence, what is to be established, how far does the purported relation extend, and which contrary facts prevent us from reaching a conclusion? The primary text supplies numerous examples. It does not, however, directly quote independent classical passages from the Bhamati, the Nyayakusumanjali and the Tattvachintamani as enacted scenes here. It would therefore be inappropriate to impose a complete philosophical exposition of their particular formulations on these chapters.

A Combined Examination of the Limits

Across the four chapters, the author's care in distinguishing forms of social evidence is notably consistent. That very strength entails a risk: people from many communities, professions and generations begin to speak with the same archival clarity. At times, unexpected ethical complexity, a character's confusion, unreliable narration, mutual bitterness or unspoken feeling quickly becomes a neatly ordered slip of paper. The surveyor in Chapter 5, Padma in Chapter 6, Shakuntala in Chapter 7 and Ramani in Chapter 8 advance the story through their practical competence, but the longer social consequences of their personal disagreements are still awaited. This criticism rests upon the limits of these four chapters; it does not yet offer a final judgment on potential developments in later ones.

Specific Questions for the Next Examination of the Primary Text

Before Chapter 9, five questions remain open. Who will measure the actual route by which water enters the Makhaniya pool, and on which day? Will testimony from both sides be obtained to correct the two recorded versions of Ramvati's name? How will written confirmation of Ramani's attendance records and wage rates be converted into actual payment? Will Shakuntala obtain a decision at the hearing concerning access to her clay site? And how will the dates and writers of the four names entered in different inks on Sarita's sheet of twenty-seven names be verified? These are unresolved points for investigation. Their answers must be established by progressively reading the novel's primary text, not fabricated here.

Chapter 9 — The Blocked Drainage Channel

The Buried Outlet: The Opening Scene and a Reframing of the Question

In the opening passage, Tara Mallik pushes a bamboo rod into the grass. Beneath the yielding soil, it encounters the hard edge of a brick. The scene is not merely one of archaeological discovery: between the pond's standing water and the possibility of a blocked outlet, it initiates the question of how knowledge is to be established. When Lalit asks whether the route is marked on the map, Tara distinguishes the line drawn on the map from the actual brick. An old record can indicate where the earth ought to be examined; it cannot by itself describe the whole condition of the ground. Tara restrains the impulse to descend immediately and clear the opening, because neither the load borne by the old masonry nor the depth below has yet been established. This decision gives the reader an inverted form of suspense: the decisive act is not the discoverer's heroism but the prevention of an unsafe intervention.

The warehouse's new plaster and strip of cement raise suspicions, but these are not accepted as direct proof of encroachment. Shyam Mallik's old sketch, Aditi's preliminary repair slip and the partly buried opening found on site constitute three distinct sources of knowledge. Tara herself limits the old sketch by saying that it does not establish ownership of the land; Aditi acknowledges that her preliminary proposal was prepared before inspecting the site; and the old brickwork does not establish a complete channel extending beneath the warehouse. By preserving these three limitations, the novel avoids becoming the simplistic story in which finding the past instantly resolves a dispute in the present. Aditi does not conceal the doubt by withdrawing her proposal; she opens the way for a new question to be put on record.

Sequence of Events: From a Discovered Object to an Official Entry for Re-examination

The chapter's direct sequence of events can be read through at least six decisive turns. First, Tara finds the brick edge and a possible position for an old outlet. Second, a discrepancy in measurement is raised between the warehouse wall and the available map; the initial proposal for a minor repair is found inadequate. Third, Urmila Rajak and those engaged in fishing identify separate rights of use at the public ghat, while the actual additional cost of carrying Urmila's washing is entered on a slip. Fourth, the separate dues owed for Lalit's timber, Shyam's bamboo weaving, the cooking of food, the transport of mud and drainage from the fields enter

the discussion. Fifth, the impulse to open an unsafe outlet is stopped and a bamboo barrier and preliminary access arrangement are decided upon. Sixth, Aditi adds a new, dated inspection note calling for re-examination alongside the old entry. After that final act, the channel remains blocked: only the formal door to inquiry has been opened.

Two negative facts must remain central to this account of events: the new filling has not been removed, and the water has not subsided that day. Stopping work is not a null result, because the foundation of the warehouse, the possibility of collapsing earth and the danger of sending water into the houses below have not yet been measured. "Work has not begun" and "the first conditions for safe work have been determined" are not equivalent statements. Tara and Aditi's intervention prevents unsafe excavation, produces separate wage slips and ensures that the relevant marks are entered into a public inspection record. Yet payment, the dispute over ownership, the drainage structure and Urmila's outstanding dues all remain unresolved. It is appropriate to recognise the force of this incompleteness as a narrative ending, rather than exaggerating it into a complete achievement.

Temporal Design, Focalisation and the Visibility of Labour

The principal narrative present extends from morning to evening on a rainy day. Last month's complaint, the incomplete wage account from an earlier desilting operation, Shyam's recollection and Aditi's earlier report enter this present as brief retrospective information. The narrator remains close to Tara and Aditi's tests, but periodically changes the visual field to Urmila's bundle, Hira's bamboo, Lalit's receipt and the time spent beside damaged hearths by women from the settlement behind the site. This succession of scenes transforms the drainage problem from a single administrative file into a public space-time constituted by many different kinds of labour.

A particularly distinctive technique appears in Urmila's practical demonstration. A drawing of the initial footpath exists, but its width is not indicated. Urmila lifts her bundle of clothes with both hands to show that the measured path is inadequate for the actual working body. Here the traditional notion of direct observation is not restricted to what an engineer sees: the user tests the sufficiency of the line with her body and the objects she carries. Hira likewise rejects the movement of leaves on the water's surface as sufficient proof of its current, while presenting depth measurement with bamboo as a technique acquired through experience. The scene avoids both extremes: dismissing working people's knowledge as superstition and treating it as infallible truth.

The Several Rights Involved in Drainage: Narratology and Social History

Is the channel a means of public drainage, or is it also used for irrigation? Does the boundary of the fishing lease apply to washing at the ghat? At whose doorway may the mud removed in desilting be deposited? Although interconnected, these questions have distinct subjects and distinct rights. The argument "there is a fishing lease, therefore its holder controls every right at the ghat" would be an illegitimate extension. In a narratologically informed discussion, identifying the parties and the precise subject of each claim is therefore important: evidence of one actual use cannot justify a conclusion about unrelated rights. Tara does not settle public drainage and private irrigation rights by drawing a single line; Aditi does not promise to open the channel without measurements.

From the standpoint of parallel history, the invisible dimension of labour is a major accomplishment of the chapter. A half-completed desilting of the pond may be called "collective merit"; but if Rukhsana's receipt for cooking disappears into an unspecified donation, Lalit's measuring tools are taken as free, and mud is left at the doorways of women in the settlement behind, that collectivity is being sustained through unequal costs. The novel begins to count these costs. In raising the suspicion of encroachment, it also insists on giving documentary significance to the constrained consent of families likely to be affected. Yet the numerical presence of Adivasi, marginalised, female or working-class characters does not by itself prove that they receive adequate voices within the story. Many disappear after a sentence or two. Whether this is a consistent choice demands scrutiny across the whole book.

Literary Achievement, Suggestions from Poetics and Countervailing Evidence

The title "The Blocked Drainage Channel" first denotes a physical obstruction to the movement of water; by the end, it awakens the expectation that the institutional obstruction to inquiry might be broken. Naira's answer—that not the channel but the way to investigate it has opened—is the chapter's central shift of meaning. At this level, the possibility of vakrokti, or oblique expression, is evident: the meaning of "opening" changes with its subject. The continued stagnation of water and the progress made on paper are not substitutes for one another; they move at unequal speeds. This narrative propriety connects the chapter to the principal story, Sarita's declaration of death, where the receipt of an application and the correction of a living person's record are likewise distinct events.

A limitation is that almost every character voices the same methodological caution: what has not been seen cannot be counted as proof. Repeated attention to inspecting objects, dating revisions, incomplete permissions and acknowledgment slips creates a discipline of facts; nevertheless, when replies become persistently explanatory, dramatic tension sometimes diminishes. The warehouse employee is not declared guilty without evidence—an ethical strength—but institutional resistance, the concealed conflict of interests and the political cost of an actual decision have yet to acquire full dramatic form. The chapter's success should therefore be located not in a final settlement but in clarifying the subjects of inquiry and bringing the bodily cost of risk into view.

Chapter 10 — The Shadow of a Name

Puranadhar: The Unstable Relationship Between a Place-Name and Its History

The previous chapter's yellow barrier reappears here, wet with rain. This small repetition establishes temporal continuity: after yesterday's written decision to "re-examine," the first condition for actual measurement is being determined today. Written permission to enter the warehouse compound has still not been obtained, so the characters remain outside the cordon. The name Puranadhar has variously referred to an old riverbed, waste ground and a low-lying area that fills during the rains. The survival of one word is no proof of one continuous geography. The novel makes this apparently simple fact the intellectual background of the whole chapter.

Sushila Mahato enters the dispute with seeds and soil. Her question cannot be reduced to a general stance "for" or "against" reopening the canal: under one arrangement the seeds will drown, and under another the planting beds will dry out. The farming family's tactile knowledge of the soil combines with the written, year-by-year account kept by a school-educated daughter to form knowledge open to subsequent examination. This is not a conflict between immediate perception and written time, but a partnership capable of correction. A map inherited from Ratan Vanpar's father opens the past from another direction; Ratan does not himself declare that map a definitive document of ownership. His ancestor's name survives in social memory, but the original map is missing.

The Course of Events: An Old Signboard, Private Wonder and an Incomplete Inquiry

The material turns of the chapter are clear: the renewed inspection of the barrier; the failure to obtain permission to enter the warehouse; Sushila's

agricultural concern and Ratan's presentation of an unverified old map; the recovery from a rubbish heap of a wooden signboard inscribed "Puranadhar"; Naira's private impression that, after the board is moved, its shadow remains momentarily on the old wall; the deliberately conditional recording of measurements because the bamboo enters uneven ground; the copy of the field map drawn by Sushila's daughter; the divergence between Ratan's and Sushila's interests; and, finally, the separate filing of three forms and the restricted recording of the experience in Naira's private notebook. The warehouse's approved map has been requested but not received, and the original position of the signboard remains unknown.

Naira's experience of the shadow introduces a significant change of register. A warehouse employee moves the wooden board, and for a few moments Naira seems to see its shadow remaining on the former wall. The narrator does not certify this marvel as an external fact. Shifting sunlight, flying dust, tired eyes or a minute temporal delay all remain open possibilities within Naira's consciousness. No other witness has been identified, the observation has not been repeated, and Naira expressly writes in her private notebook that it is not evidence for judicial fact-finding. To turn it either into a certain law of magic or into a conclusive pathological diagnosis of illusion would therefore contradict the primary text.

A Narratological Departure: External Light and Inner Time

The immediate danger in Chapter 9 was clearly physical; in Chapter 10 the sensation of a momentary delay in time destabilises the narrative's realism. The crucial distinction is not between "marvellous" and "false," but between an external event authorised by the narrator and the private experience of a character. The third-person narration approaches Naira's astonishment, reserve and self-doubt without making her experience universally shared. This is a use of limited internal focalisation. The shadow evokes a metaphorical relationship with the time of the old name: the board has changed position, while the imprint of its name seems to stand for a moment longer in its former place. The metaphor's effect, however, does not take the place of material evidence.

Despite the dreamlike quality of the episode, the chapter does not achieve "credibility" simply by locking the experience away in a character's private pages; it establishes two different modes of reading public and private memory. Naira asks Tara to photograph only the plaster, not to record the story of the shadow. Nor does she mention it to Sarita at home. This silence is not a conspiracy driven by fear: it concerns differing grades of evidence and anxiety about the social assessment of an uncertain experience. The reader knows no more than Naira about whether the shadow on the wall was actually delayed. The limit of knowledge thus

becomes a felt aspect of the plot rather than remaining merely a lesson delivered by a character.

The Ratan–Sushila Dispute: Present Crops Must Not Be Erased in the Name of Past History

Ratan's old map and Sushila's evidence about seasonal cultivation cannot simply cancel one another out. Ratan wants the history of his grandmother's footpath to be visible; Sushila makes the risks to her present seeds visible. The same strip of land may have different uses at different times. From a narratological standpoint, a proper question for dialogue is that the subject of the proposition "a waterway existed here formerly" is not the subject of "there is a right to the present crop." Unless time, area and the intended reach of the evidence are identified, a linear inference such as "if it was a river, it cannot be a field" has not been established as valid. Sushila's words—do not wipe out my rice crop today because of an old story—give this philosophical difference a bodily edge.

Rani Halalkhor's team removes glass and barbed wire without complete safety equipment; the consignment number on Gomati Beldar's daily receipt is unclear; and Suraj Gangota's application shows that an old episode of erosion and a debt still being serviced belong to different temporal registers. These references indicate the novel's broad ambition for parallel history, but the inner lives of these three people are not granted extensive narrative space here. The recurring technique of "new name plus one application" ensures social presence while potentially weakening the pace and depth of character development. Criticism should not deny their presence, but neither should it call a momentary detail a fully developed independent story.

The Symbolism of the Name, Language and a Test of the Limits

The inscription "Puranadhar" on the wooden board is a material remnant of memory; it is not a boundary pillar and may have served merely as an information sign. Naira records separately where the board was found, the old lettering and the unknown source. The doubled meaning of the name's shadow—the name of an earlier geography and the extraordinary experience of a shadow—turns the title into the chapter's unifying metaphor. Alongside this artistic effect, the evening's pickle and bread at home, and talk about Sanket's telephone, add a light voice of everyday life to remembrance. The reader's affective experience is not restricted to mystery or pathos.

An important achievement of this chapter is that the preceding evidence-centred narrative is creatively challenged by a subtle and unreliable experience. Even so, that private incident remains almost wholly on a

separate level, with negligible immediate social consequences. It may be understood as deliberate indeterminacy; whether such moments recur later in the long novel will determine whether this becomes a central narrative sensitivity or merely marvellous ornament. A definitive judgment based on this chapter alone would be unwarranted.

Chapter 11 — My Phone, My Conditions

The Image of a Mark: The Distance Between Ownership, Consent and Interpretation

The chapter opens with a red line, the backs of two men and the indistinct corner of a receipt appearing together on the screen of Sanket's phone. Enlarging the picture makes the colour clearer, but the writing on the receipt becomes blurred. This small digital detail gives visible form to the central evidentiary problem: enlarging an image does not make every fact clearer. Sanket took the photograph himself, but the rights of those whose backs or papers happened to enter the frame are not wholly absorbed into the photographer's rights. Naira rejects the argument that permission is unnecessary merely because faces are not visible, yet she does not take the phone into her own hands. Sanket decides to keep the original, show only those features of the site that are necessary, and refrain from sending it to a public group.

When Tara clarifies the purpose of using the photograph—to check markers on the site, not to display people publicly—Sanket shows it to her. The time is available, but the distance is not remembered; Tara does not supply that distance from imagination. A warehouse worker describes several possible uses for the red mark, but does not know who made this particular one. Although the colour of the worker's clothing matches what can be seen in the picture, no identification of the worker as its subject is pronounced. The corner of the receipt might concern someone's entitlement or earnings. In this way Sanket's initial curiosity turns into an ethical question about consent.

Sequence of Events: The Changing Definition of a Photograph

The first decisive moment is Sanket's decision to demand a written limit on keeping and using the image. Second, on viewing the picture, Tara checks its source, time and original measurements; the coloured mark still proves neither encroachment nor a blockage to water. Third, at a meeting in Pachhiyari Chaur, Sushila describes the spread of seasonal water and the risks to cultivation. Fourth, the rainy-season detour made by girls carrying grass, Ramesh's vegetable beds, Devaki's route for livestock and seasonal fishing uses are marked separately on one map. Fifth, the terms for wages,

songs, food and participation in the work are written down; labour performed by a woman and previously called "help" is entered as paid work. Sixth, Sanket refuses pressure to circulate the original photograph in a group, while Tara makes public her own site diagram with people omitted. Seventh, a written agreement provides that the original photograph will stay securely on Sanket's telephone and no public copy will be issued; a preliminary seasonal map of the chaur is prepared for subsequent checking.

In this sequence, "consent" is not one universal permission granted once and for all. It is a right defined by the particular person, material, purpose, copy and limits of circulation. The original photograph remains on Sanket's phone; Tara makes the site map public. The question of the blocked drainage channel remains open. At the end of the description, Sanket writes beneath the photograph that the purpose of the mark is unknown and the other people's consent is still outstanding. The significance of this action exceeds a simple lesson about the proper use of technology: a child character acquires the capacity to determine the conditions under which an object belonging to him may be used.

The Seasonal Chaur: Several Temporal Rights within One Piece of Land

The defining narrative feature of Pachhiyari Chaur is that land described as an "empty place" has different uses in different seasons. The livestock path in dry weather, the marshy spread of water during the rains, seasonal fishing, rice nurseries, vegetable beds and the lengthy detour taken by grass carriers cannot be contained in a single "static" map. Sushila's first demand is that the lines be named before they are coloured. Without clearly defined meanings and seasonal purposes, colour offers only visual convenience, not knowledge. Recording the time taken on foot alongside the measurements—particularly the delay incurred by a girl walking with grass—transforms the site into a social space-time.

The middle of the chaur is white on the municipality's printed map, whereas the map made by residents contains many livelihoods there. The author does not treat the blank colour as equivalent to an absence of rights; at the same time, the residents' map is presented as a supplement to engineering measurement, not its replacement. The novel's politics of knowledge takes shape through this dual restraint. In narratological terms, confusion arises when the qualifications of a statement—the part of the place, season, type of use, rights of an agent and source—are not made explicit. Although the novel does not stage a formal scholastic disputation, locating the calendar of everyday life within a space left white on a map is a useful narrative form of examining evidence.

The Meaning of Collective Labour: From Attendance to the Right to Decide

At the meeting concerning the sharing of seeds and water, work is not distributed by caste or household: people choose according to bodily capacity, willingness and skill. A young man recording names enters a woman's whole day of work as "help"; at Sushila's objection, the hours and wages are recorded. This small correction raises the question of public respect: work that produces a result should be registered together with its material value as labour. Payment for a singer's performance, and permission to sing, likewise require ethical care comparable to the recording of wages, even though artistic autonomy cannot be fully reduced to a market rate.

Renu Gondhi, Asha Bhumij, Binu Darai, Hira Meche, Tulsi Donwar, Kiran and slips concerning the river's different names signal the novel's social breadth. The author does not misleadingly join every temporary piece of information into "the same problem." The translation of a bilingual slip remains unverified; documentary references to the Budhi Gandak and the Adhwara do not establish that they are branches of the Tilwaha. Such linguistic and geographical restraint matters. Even so, many names enter a single meeting rapidly, and the reader may reach the next document before gaining a sense of the particular conflicts within their private lives. The tension between social inclusion and the memorability of individual characters is a real structural limitation.

Narrative Time, the Child's Perspective and Critical Counterargument

The narration remains within one day, from wiping the photograph in the morning to locking it away at night with a private annotation. Beginning and end return to the same object, but its ethical status has changed. Initially the red mark was an object of curiosity; by the end it has become a specific piece of visual material explicitly labelled as having an unknown purpose. The scenes in the chaur open this domestic-digital thread into a wider society. Sanket's childhood is not represented here as ethical immaturity, but as learning to argue and to set conditions. Naira guides him, yet does not snatch away his telephone; at the public meeting, neither does she answer on Sanket's behalf. The restraint creates a genuine dramatic change in the character's development.

A weakness is the exceptional speed with which so many participants reach considered agreement. There is pressure to secure a public image, but threats to spread the original photograph by force, political misuse and protracted disputes over the recognition of labour have not yet been adequately developed. Even if the author intends to demonstrate an ideal of specific consent, the depth of resistance within the fictional world may

be limited. The language finds an authentic beauty in "I do not know," but its continuous repetition will require artistic variation in subsequent chapters.

Chapter 12 — The City Behind the Ghat

Ramani's Fishing Lease: The Complete Statement of a Right Beyond the Name

At the opening, Ramani Bind spreads a fishing net damp with the night's dew. Fish baskets are forbidden on the ghat's narrow steps, but the identity of the person authorised to enforce the ban is unclear. On the first page of her copy of the fishing lease, a man's name is recorded; the second page is incomplete. The central difficulty is not the quantity of fish: where are the full conditions concerning the duration of the lease, the extent of the waters, access, payments, the contractor's share and the woman's name? Hira's observation that a boat route and a fishing boundary may be different establishes this multiplicity of rights in the opening scene. The half-page of paper is not an easy metaphor for "nothing has been found"; it is an incomplete document with legal uses.

The accumulation of marks over the preceding four chapters now becomes an open reading of accounts. The municipality's printed map and the residents' map are not drawn to the same scale; Tara first records the year of construction and the scale of measurement. Aditi is required to clarify whether the line showing the channel near the warehouse indicates a pond boundary, a drainage facility or a revenue plot. The need to request separate records from the municipal estates branch and the revenue office becomes established. The case thereby avoids the one-sided conclusion: "People's paths appear in a space left white on the map, therefore encroachment is proven."

Sequence of Events: Up to Acknowledgment of the Application, Not a Resolution

First comes Ramani's objection to the incomplete lease; second, a comparison of the conflicting notions of use shown by public and community maps; third, a separate entry for Suraj's loan documents concerning land lost to erosion; fourth, Sugni's written demand that labourers participate in the survey and Mamata's demand for safety equipment; fifth, a decision to read the public expenditure recorded in the water register but not the private register of twenty-seven names; sixth, formal acknowledgment of requests for two separate estates and revenue files; seventh, Ramani's request for the complete lease annexure and a requirement that any new restriction or fee be supported by a reasoned

order; eighth, the setting of a date for an open meeting to elect the workers' team, with Mamata's safety slip as the first agenda item; and ninth, a written interim arrangement forbidding the closure of verified public footpaths without a hearing or any new drainage intervention without measurement and risk assessment. After all this, the lease has not been obtained, the unpaid debt has not been settled, and ownership of the land has not been proved.

This sequence cannot be concluded with the assertion that "the meeting was a success" or "the city has delivered justice." The verifiable achievements are an acknowledgment number, separate subjects for inquiry, provisional restrictions on use and specific grounds for the next hearing. Ramani is told that the complete lease will be provided the following day, but its receipt is not shown within the chapter. Tulsi takes home the documents concerning the debt on the vanished field; the entry reads "claim outstanding," not "land vacated." The meeting to elect Sugni's team has been fixed, but the team has not yet been formed. Procedure is not merely a device for prolonging the plot: it delineates the incomplete stages through which rights may become accessible.

Publicity and Privacy: Two Registers, Two Ethical Rules

In the chapter's sharpest episode, Naira reads from the water register the public expenditure and the names of ponds and places, while omitting private addresses and treatment details. A young man then demands that Sarita's list of twenty-seven names also be read. Naira refuses: the right to scrutinise public accounts of water expenditure is not the same as the right to expose the names of living people whose safety may be affected. The same platform, the same table or the word "transparency" does not suspend personal protection. The privacy question from Chapter 2 returns here as a real conflict on a public platform. The repetition is narratively justified because a decision first made inside the home is now tested under the immediate pressure of a gathering.

A relevant narratological argument here rejects the unproved generalisation that these are "the same kind of paper": the water register accounts for public spending, whereas the register of names contains sensitive information affecting private persons' security. The fact that both are written does not subject both to the same rule of publication. The subject, purpose, authenticity, holder of the relevant right and archival source of a statement must be identified separately. This is especially important to the Videha parallel-history perspective: bringing the history of marginalised people into the archive does not mean taking possession of their privacy. An institution committed to parallel history must itself remain answerable to the self-determination of the people who provide its sources.

Seasons, River and City: Constructing a Public Space-Time

The ghat, pond, chaur, courtyard of the municipal library, verandas and the plot behind the warehouse create an expanded urban geography. The city here is not merely a place of large buildings; it is composed of scales of measurement, debts, leases, fares, safety equipment, libraries, remuneration for songs and children's play. The white colour marking "vacant land" is challenged by footprints spanning three generations, although the dates of claims represented by new lines must also be examined separately. The boundary of Suraj's old field cannot replace the river's present line of erosion; the time over which a debt must be repaid differs from the natural time of the river's geography. Owing to this temporal inequality, "it existed formerly," "it does not exist today" and "a debt remains outstanding on paper" can all describe different conditions of truth concerning the same property.

Mamata Hari's safety slip draws the ethical centre of the story towards the physical body. Empty spaces against gloves and shoes reveal the actual cost concealed by an official entry that says "work completed." Sugni seeks not simply a presence at the survey but a right to decide at an open meeting that will elect the team. Ramani demands the full annexure specifying her fishing rights. These three requests bring women's labour into view at three levels: physical risk, collective leadership and lawful access to resources. To generalise from them that "all the women have been empowered" would be damaging, for each demand has reached a different stage of fulfilment.

The distinction between the regular folk reading in Phagun and the special meeting organised in the rainy season lends credibility to narrative time. Karim Dafali's drum and the girls' two lines of song add cultural memory, but the performers' labour is not assumed to be free material for a festival. The children's game with wooden boats provides a small rhythmic change amid arguments about documents. Their reactions to victory and defeat lighten the heavy tone of a public hearing; it would be unnecessary to turn the game into a "direct metaphor" for the fishing lease. The scene grants the children of the fictional world an independent time of immediate enjoyment.

Creative Achievement and Possible Structural Limitations

At the end, Ramani has an acknowledgment number, not the complete lease; Sugni has a date for the next meeting, not equipment; and Tulsi has a securely recorded claim, not the field. Such an ending, both negative and positive, saves the novel's politics of rights from a sentimental celebration of victory. The title "The City Behind the Ghat" reverses both geography and institutional perspective: the people of the ghat are not simply located

on the city's periphery; they are agents who redefine the meaning of its public documents. The closing image of a boat and children's play leaves the future open.

Yet the gathering of many communities, documents, receipts, objections, songs and decisions within a single day is dense in relation to the reader's experience. In some places the scene resembles the dramatic breadth of a social novel; elsewhere, a direct transcript of policy training. Whether the linguistic differences among voices are sufficiently developed will need to be examined in subsequent chapters of the complete novel; many characters present a dispute and immediately assent to a cautious conclusion. If every character always speaks with the same evidentiary restraint, nominal polyphony will not amount to a genuine difference of philosophical positions. This critical concern cannot be suppressed in the name of the author's social purpose.

Adi Parva / Bala Kanda: Combined Narratological Conclusions on Chapters 9–12

From "Finding an Outlet" to "Requesting Two Files"

Across the four chapters, the actual level of achievement rises, but the claim of a solution does not. In Chapter 9 a sign of the outlet is found and unsafe excavation is averted. In Chapter 10 an inscribed signboard and domestic-agricultural maps are recovered, but no boundary is established. In Chapter 11 an understanding develops of the changing seasonal uses relevant to a public map, while the photograph remains under the control of the person who produced it. In Chapter 12 formal requests are made for two independent government files, and interim safety conditions are written down for public use pending inquiry. This trajectory constitutes an independent narrative construction: an improvement in the quality of the questions, rather than a dramatic announcement that the problems are solved.

Within the broader perspective of the Adi Parva, this sequence unfolds the theme of ancient dynastic origins as an inquiry into the origins of rights in the modern city. Yet none of these four chapters contains a separate scene situated in the ancient time of Janaka, Satyavati or the Kuru dynasty. In some earlier narrative entries, "dual-temporal intertextuality" appears as a possible signal; here, the direct narrative evidence for it lies chiefly in memories of earlier chapters and in the composition of the work as a whole. Chapters 9 and 11 do not present an independent mythological timeline. Epic titles and the division into parvas open questions for criticism, but do not justify claiming that an event exactly corresponding to the Mahabharata occurs in every chapter.

The Evidentiary Sequence: Four Objects and Four Limits

The brick trace in Chapter 9 provides grounds for inspecting the site; it does not prove wrongdoing by the warehouse. The wooden signboard in Chapter 10 is a material remnant of geographical memory, not a boundary pillar; the shadow is a private experience, not an official fact. The digital photograph in Chapter 11 may offer visual evidence of a location, but the purpose of the colour, identification of the people and permission for public circulation remain separately uncertain. The official acknowledgment number in Chapter 12 establishes that an application has formally been received, not that the requested lease annexure has been supplied or a decision on rights reached. As the type of object changes, so too do the proposition to be established and the limits of its evidence. Through these distinctions the reader learns a discipline of inference.

A Shared Examination of Focalisation and Narrative Rhythm

Chapter 9 sets numerous scenes of working people's lives around Tara and Aditi's inspection; Chapter 10 opens a marvellous instant within Naira's private consciousness; Chapter 11 finds an intimate movement among Sanket's age, his photograph and his right to determine consent; Chapter 12 expands into the many voices of a public gathering. The narrative rhythm thus forms a sequence: inspection → experience → a bounded personal decision → public hearing. These do not all happen simultaneously. The directly narrated present consists of successive days, into which the subsidiary times of old ledgers, records, seasonal memories and slips of objection enter. The child's viewpoint and the knowledge of the working body do not declare that everything opposed to expertise is right; rather, they subject the monopoly of expert knowledge to context-sensitive examination.

A reading of rasa and dhvani in this group of chapters cannot flatten the laughter over rice and pickle at home, a child's marbles and boat games, Naira's momentary hesitation, Mamata's missing protective equipment and Ramani's incomplete lease into one uniform emotional composition. Pain arising from labour remains in the background; there is resolve in setting conditions for the use of one's own belongings and, intermittently, an easy humour. The characters are not regarded merely as objects of pity. Nevertheless, overly deliberate exchanges of questions and answers can incline the story towards didactic terminology; the danger of restraining creative disagreement remains open.

An Initial Overall Assessment of Chapters 1–12

Across the first twelve chapters, the enlargement of the fictional field from "The Kitchen of the Dead" to the city's public map has been carefully

prepared. The notice declaring a living woman dead, the privacy of twenty-seven names, Fakira's sense of time, the ancient water-related scene involving Satyavati, Janaka's land measurement, the household ledger, the bench of five generations, the Simatirtha letter, the blocked drainage channel, the shadow of a name, Sanket's image and the reading of the city's accounts form a succession of objects. The central critical thread of that succession is this: a written name, a visible object, a spoken statement, a remembered experience and a received application each have their own evidentiary limits. When the author connects those limits to social justice, evidence ceases to be merely a legal term and becomes a question involving the household kitchen, the river ghat, a school map and wages owed for labour.

The study of the first twelve chapters cannot, however, sustain a judgment on the quality of an entire novel of 216 chapters. The principal questions still open are these: to what extent will references to numerous characters develop into complete lives? Where will the method of examining evidence collide with human inconsistency and uncontrolled violence? How far will epic and philosophical timelines transform the social questions posed at the beginning? And how will narrative momentum be maintained if readers continually encounter decisions that remain incomplete? These are questions for the analysis of subsequent chapters, not defects or achievements decided in advance.

Sabha Parva / Ayodhya Kanda

Chapter 13 — The Dead Woman Who Was Summoned

The Stage Placard and the Living Body: The Public Reappearance of the Question

The chapter opens in the morning with Sarita's name on an inverted placard on the stage of a relief-distribution meeting. Sarita does not demand a change of name on the stage merely to see it altered: she wants her name to be heard from her own mouth. The loosely fixed bamboo peg, the scraped palm of the young man at work and Sarita's vessel of water prevent the opening from becoming simply a spectacle of official administration. Here is a living person giving water to another injured body even as her name hangs above her as the designation of a deceased relief beneficiary. The scene carries the question first raised in the novel's kitchen from private space into the domain of public utterance.

Sarita brings three distinct papers: a copy of the notice declaring her dead, her earlier application for registration of her living presence, and a duplicate medicine slip issued in the name of her husband, who died seventeen years earlier. The original sheet containing twenty-seven names remains secure at home. That choice is itself a narrative event. Where the display of the maximum number of documents could produce sensation, the character declines to expose unnecessary sensitive information. She also keeps the receipt numbers of two property files concerning the ghat separate from the dispute over the relief list. Instead of manufacturing a new mystery, Chapter 13 brings one question from among those already raised to the centre of a public platform.

Register of Events: Humiliation, Resistance and Incomplete Correction of the Record

The first significant circumstance is the preparation of a public benefit-distribution list on the basis of an earlier, erroneous entry recording death. The second is an attempt to change Sarita's status silently by means of an informal instruction at Rama Karna's desk. Rama stops the process by demanding an order in writing and a signature. Third, she does not assume that she possesses the authority to strike out the previous entry; instead, she registers the application in a separate register of disputes and provides an acknowledgment slip. At this point Sarita's identity has not been corrected in the office. A formal objection has merely been received.

The decisive scene comes when the microphone calls upon a representative of 'the family of the late Sarita Das'. Naira tries to take her mother's hand,

but Sarita decides to climb the steps herself. Taking her for a dependent, the organiser offers an envelope; Sarita refuses it and declares that she herself is the person pronounced dead. What she rejects here is not the very possibility of claiming assistance, but the public utterance of a false death status. She insists that the process for correcting the mistake be recorded and that eligibility for assistance be genuinely examined as well. Her object is to enable two separate procedures—the recognition of her life and the examination of an economic entitlement—rather than merging one into the other.

The fourth change is the official's announcement: the death status may be erroneous, but full verification cannot take place on the spot, and no payment will be made without an identity check. He instructs that the placard be removed; he does not issue a final order correcting the old list. The fifth change, achieved through Naira's and Rama's efforts, is the recording of Sarita's statement under the description 'Disputed death status—statement of the person presenting herself'. By noon, two copies of the statement have been made, signed and safeguarded with an acknowledgment. The death entry is still not cancelled, while the complaint about medicine distribution remains under separate investigation. At the end comes news of another meeting to which Ruhani will be invited to the representative's chair. The reader learns that the field for voting rights is blank, though Ruhani does not yet know it. This last distribution of information prepares the causal entrance into the next chapter.

Narrative Time, Focalisation and the Control of Information

The principal course of action occupies one day, from the morning preparations for the stage to cooking in the evening. Between tending a scraped palm in the morning and washing rice at dusk, the narrative's represented duration is dominated by the meeting, the office desk and the microphone. The husband's death seventeen years earlier returns within the statement made in the present. It should be read not as a separately elaborated flashback but through its present relevance as evidence. The third-person narrator can approach Sarita's dissent, Naira's waiting and Rama's discipline as a keeper of records. Moreover, in the final passage, the narrator gives the reader information that lies beyond Ruhani's present knowledge. The distinction between the character's limited apprehension and the narrator's wider information is exact.

The placard on the stage is inverted much as an institutional sentence can read a private life backwards. The moment it is opened produces dramatic irony; yet Sarita's ascent, the loose steps and her aching feet bring the narrative back to physical danger. A microphone magnifies a voice; it does not perform verification. Public announcement extends the reach of a

statement, but cannot itself establish its truth. It would therefore be improper to assume that the official status automatically changed when Sarita appeared in person. Reading the page herself, Sarita acknowledges precisely this limitation.

Different Problems Behind Different Names: Collectivity Without Uniformity

Savitri Sardar's addresses in two villages have changed through displacement after the flood; correcting her present address would not settle the older unpaid assistance. An office has misread the word 'Kisan' in Niranjan Kisan's name as an occupational designation, disrupting bank details. Name, profession and account cannot all be compressed into a single field. Arun Barnwal puts the settlement of outstanding tax accounts before the garland and public recognition accorded to donors over the microphone. A young woman bringing tea protests when milk, sugar and the work of carrying them are made invisible in the name of free public service. None of these four instances amounts to the same wrong as declaring Sarita dead. Together they show the different discrepancies of naming, relief, accounts and labour coexisting within the public meeting.

The distinct acknowledgment numbers obtained by Savitri and Niranjan save the story from a centralised construction in which a single heroine solves everybody's suffering. Sarita does not invent a time frame for someone else's application; drawing only on her own experience, she recommends preserving acknowledgment slips. Here the woman is not merely a symbol but an equal participant who accepts the limits of her knowledge. A child's small touch, a chipped teacup and shared laughter restore ordinary daily life amid public humiliation. Yet the rapid arrival of many social micro-narratives leaves little space for Savitri's, Niranjan's and Arun's inner conflicts. The tension between social plurality and the development of an individual life-story is unmistakable.

Consent, Evidence and a Reading Through Indian Criticism

Sanket does not turn on the camera. Only after Sarita's signal does he write down the words spoken into the microphone. Holding a public meeting does not authorise the publication of every private slip of paper. A person's visible presence, a written copy of her statement and a recording authorised by her are three different categories. Rama's dispatch or receipt number proves that an application has been received, not that a correction has been made or that irregular medicine distribution has been established. The official's statement that 'there may be an error' acknowledges a possibility, not an adjudicated fact. A source-conscious narratological examination asks: who originated the written page, what can it establish, and what proposition remains to be demonstrated? The

absence of one register cannot automatically establish a separate wrongdoing.

From the standpoint of rasa, Sarita's laughter and her memory of the hearth within a painful scene of humiliation prevent her from becoming an inert figure of mourning. The difference between 'hearing a name' and 'writing it correctly' remains as a resonance of language; without constructing an overtly poetic metaphor, the microphone, placard, water vessel and kitchen become unequal media through which social justice is approached. The chapter's artistic strength lies in the distance between an immediately visible scene and the formal correction of a record. Its limitation is that many characters repeatedly speak with precise archival caution, at times threatening to turn dialogue into a lesson in ethical instruction. Even so, Sarita's ascent on her own feet when announced as dead, and her reading and acceptance of the written statement herself, prevent the narrative from dissolving into abstract argument.

Chapter 14 — The Representative's Chair

Invitation and Voting Rights: The Social Deception of Visible Honour

Behind the blue-covered chair reserved for Ruhani is written 'Community Representative', yet her name is absent from among the eighteen voting members listed in the municipal committee's green-bound register. The entry register at the door supplies three predetermined categories—'male', 'female' and 'special guest'. This classification does not itself answer the question of Ruhani's membership. Confronted with ceremonial honour, she asks for the original rules and learns that the committee recommends priorities concerning relief, shelters, access to ghats and drainage. Its vote is not itself a governmental order, but it influences grants and priorities. Exclusion from voting is consequently more than a decorative insult: it keeps her from the preliminary stage at which decisions take shape.

The story's subtle irony is that the most conspicuous chair carries no real authority. Ruhani accepts the garland, thanks the young man and chooses an open bench instead of the blue chair. By taking the garland in her hand and placing it on a table rather than creating a spectacle of refusal, she distinguishes the young man's labour from the institution's deception. He was distributing the garland on instruction; he too lacked decision-making authority. The narrator avoids the rigid simplification of an entire community standing against every other individual, and reveals a hierarchy of responsibility within the institution.

Register of Events: From Reading the Rules to a New Agenda Entry

First, Ruhani's question makes clear the separation between honour at admission and the register of voting rights. Second, once the formal meeting begins, permanent members vote on priorities for the relief shelter. Ruhani speaks, but her raised hand is not counted as a vote. Third, she objects: why should those whose housing, treatment and travel are being decided have no role in choosing the members? Fourth, when the secretary records her written proposal merely as a 'suggestion', she challenges that classification and has her proposal on membership and voting rights entered separately from her objection to unrestricted circulation of the shelter's private list of patients.

Fifth, the members agree to place a review of the rules on the agenda of the next public meeting. That is not the acquisition of voting rights today. The question of protecting the shelter's patient list is also referred to the relevant service worker and accountant for examination; no final rule has been established. A copy of the proceedings, bearing its acknowledgment number, is requested. Finally, Ruhani accepts the boundary set by Champa's private words: if Champa is absent from the next meeting, consent must not be filled in under her name. The problems of representation within the external institution and within the shelter test each other ethically.

Focalised Consciousness, Temporal Connections and the Organisation of Dialogue

The chapter follows one day, from morning to evening, through the community building, courtyard, open bench and road home. Ruhani has received her invitation because of the meeting held in the preceding chapter; Naira also arrives to ask about the status of Sarita's statement. The narrator remains principally close to Ruhani's inner reflections, but assigns separate importance to Champa's expenses, Basanti's labour and Naira's caution with written evidence. Thus 'community' becomes not an unknowable collective mind but a group of different people with individual interests and immediate constraints.

The predominance of dialogue should not be established merely by numerical proportion. What matters is the action performed by each verbal resistance: Ruhani reads the rulebook, Champa defines the confidential limits of information, Basanti demands the proper registration of her community name, and Shabnam rejects a mistaken assumption about her official status. These four voices serve different material purposes. Yet some sentences—particularly the opposition of 'rights' to 'honour'—occasionally sound like polished passages from an essay. If every character speaks in the same precise terminology, the

author's normative argument may spread where the polyphony of distinct voices ought to develop.

Basanti, Shabnam and Neeraj: Unequal Sources of Names and Offices

Basanti has 'Pan Sawasi Panar' entered in her vendor register, because the older official synonym does not correspond to her family's self-identification. She does not demand that the old word be erased and its source destroyed; she asks for the different entries to be linked. The reason is specific: when earlier market-fee receipts can be connected with the name in the new register, continuity of livelihood and documentation becomes visible. This is a question of self-naming within the time of labour. Taking time away from the market stall to correct a name also has an economic cost.

Because of her family surname, Shabnam Mallik is mistaken for an authorised office representative, and somebody attempts to hand her a confidential file; she refers it to the authorised desk. Neeraj Panda refuses to combine assistance due to a deceased person's family with voluntary ritual offerings. None of these incidents proves a caste, religion or occupation to be an intrinsically exemplary moral category. Rather, they reveal independent distinctions between occupational work, voluntary religious practice, archival authority and the sound of names within the same society. Entitlement to assistance must be examined on its own grounds; an offering for a religious rite depends on personal choice and means. Their appearance at a common event cannot turn them into a single payment.

Champa's Independent Consent: Counterpoint Within Representation

The chapter would lose depth if it made Ruhani an invariably correct leader against injustice. Champa herself depends on the shelter, yet Ruhani's community representation does not automatically authorise the disclosure of details about her treatment. Champa distinguishes 'information needed for treatment' from 'information supplied to the audience at the meeting'. Her joke beside a plate of pua reminds Ruhani that even within the shelter she has sometimes made hurried decisions on someone else's behalf. Champa's final insistence—that nobody may fill in consent under her name when she is absent—is the chapter's small but genuine ethical turning point.

Here the Indian-poetic question of aucitya, or contextual propriety, is clear. The garland, blue chair, green register, plate of pua and Champa's watch are not interchangeable declarative symbols of a single 'right'. They

have unequal functions in characters' lives, bodies, celebrations and labour. The chair is an object of visible recognition; the green-bound volume is the instrument of lawfully constituted voting rights; the watch measures the costs of treatment, fares and disrupted livelihood. Such relations among objects give the characters practical reasons for speaking. One limitation is that several bureaucratic questions end with a promise of inclusion on the next agenda. If this structure continues to recur, narrative tension may subside into procedural repetition. For now, however, Ruhani's change in requiring consent even within her own shelter extends the story beyond the institution it criticises.

Chapter 15 — Draupadi's Question

Two Narrative Times: The Assembly of Wagers and the Modern Office of Rights

The chapter begins with the faint sound of dice in the assembly hall of Hastinapura. The polished floor, elevated seats and the strained breathing of the gathering construct the tension of the royal court. Yudhishthira has lost his kingdom and brothers in gambling. Shakuni raises the stakes further; in Draupadi's absence, her very life is declared an object available for wager. Draupadi puts the fundamental question to the messenger: was she staked before the king lost himself, or afterwards? Its centre is not merely the 'rules' of gambling, but the rights remaining to a defeated man and the consent of an independent person. The ancient temporal strand is not a fanciful modern reincarnation; it is the narrative means of reconsidering an original epic crisis within a contemporary field of meaning.

Videhapur enters at dusk from the seventh passage onward. Naira lays on one table the acknowledgment of Sarita's living presence and the acknowledgment of Ruhani's proposal for membership. One page documents that 'a statement was heard'; the other demands a 'vote in making decisions'. Both are stamped, yet they do not confer equal rights. The transition does not decree that Draupadi and Sarita have 'the same story'. The historical and institutional differences between a wager in the royal assembly and a modern governmental file remain intact. The reader is led to ask: how far is the consent of the person made the object of a decision recognised?

Register of Events: From the Repeated Question to a New Hearing

The decisive moments in the ancient sequence are Yudhishthira's loss; the sending of the messenger to Draupadi; her counter-question; the messenger's return without an answer; the different responses of Bhishma

and Vidura; Draupadi's unwanted public appearance; and the attempt to humiliate her. Chapter 15 does not resolve these events. It stops immediately before Vikarna rises upon hearing the question, allowing the ancient decision-scene to continue in Chapter 16. The order of the narration is suspended here for an effect of renewed reading: the question left unanswered in speech becomes the cause of resistance in the next chapter.

In the modern sequence, Anita Chaupal reaches Naira's home with an application concerning her incorrect social classification, while Salma Sheikh brings evidence of a delay in treating an elderly patient at the hospital because of an identity check. Naira does not make Anita's private genealogical details public. She records Salma's treatment delay and Anita's classification on separate sheets. Sanket wishes to take a photograph but sees Anita's discomfort and lowers his phone. This small scene connects the patriarchal issue of staking a person without permission to the practice of consent and privacy in present life. Yet declining to take the photograph is an immediate ethical choice, not the final settlement of the registered complaints.

The following morning, Salma questions why the hospital register contains the patient's admission time but leaves the time treatment began blank. Aniruddha asks for a written account of events; he does not pronounce a final departmental finding of guilt. Salma chooses to put her own name on the statement, while keeping the patient's personal name out of public view. At the office, Anita learns that a copy of the original source document is unavailable and demands a written explanation from the official; she will not have private details read at an open meeting. By the chapter's end, Salma's acknowledgment and Anita's request for the source document remain separate and secure. The modern 'result' of Draupadi's question is not miraculous justice but two women demonstrably exercising the specific right to demand an answer.

Narrative Time, Duration and the Work of Focalisation

The order of narration is not linear. The narrator moves from the ancient assembly to a modern evening (passages 7–15), back to the ancient scene (16–19), to the hospital and office on the next modern morning (20–30), back to Hastinapura (31–33), and finally to a modern night (34–36). There is no literal journey between these periods; the scenes replace one another because of a shared social question. Narrative duration also varies: one instant of the dice game and the messenger's question are expanded, whereas several procedural hours in the modern office are condensed. This uneven pace keeps Draupadi's question open in the reader's mind throughout the intervening modern scenes.

In Hastinapura the narrator brings into view Vidura's apprehension, Bhishma's uncertainty and Vikarna's growing courage. The modern scenes approach Naira's reflections, Salma's risk to her livelihood, Anita's fear for her privacy and Sarita's exhaustion. Rather than a fixed 'woman's perspective', focalisation moves from consciousness to consciousness according to the scene. Draupadi protests against being made an object within the story; Anita demands the source of an entry; Salma has the delay in medical procedure documented. These are not historically identical women but different languages of dispute over rights.

Narratology: Does a "Won Wager" Automatically Constitute Lawful Ownership?

Draupadi's question exposes the difficulty of deriving moral legitimacy from the result of a game recognised within a legal order. The assumption that possession of Draupadi automatically passed to another party when Yudhishthira lost rests on an unestablished universal relation in its central premise: it has not been shown that the declaration of a wager extinguishes the consent of an independent person. To transform the historical controversies of ancient rajadharma into a single sentence of modern law would not amount to classical interpretation. Yet the novel deliberately reconstructs this problem of reasoning in narrative form. Bhishma's silence does not mean that 'justice has been established'; nor does Vidura's objection by itself become an institutional judgment.

The modern examination of evidence is different. An incorrect social-classification entry against Anita's name becomes unreliable without its source document: 'it is written in the register' demonstrates the existence of an entry, not its truth. A blank field for the time treatment began in Salma's register raises a possible problem of delay, but it cannot alone establish a specific medical offence. Salma therefore demands a written examination of the sequence without publicising the patient's identity. The separation of written evidence, direct observation, received statements and inference is an ethical use of 'proof', not the performance of philosophical formulae.

Women's Right to Speak and Unexpected Dramatic Resistance

Salma asks that her own name appear in the statement. A supposedly universal rule of 'privacy', then, must not take away her freedom to name herself. Anita makes the opposite choice, declining to have her name broadcast at an open meeting. One character wishes to display her name; another wishes to limit its circulation. Respect for these conflicting wishes, rather than a rigid formula of women's rights, is a notable achievement of the novel. At Ruhani's shelter, Champa praises her appropriate silence: she did not appear as Anita's representative without permission. This scene of

self-restraint indicates the inner development of the leader-character introduced in Chapter 14.

The lamps of Draupadi's assembly hall and the shifting lights reflected in Videhapur's large pond make a visual connection, but an interruption of light is not treated as a literal omen. The poetic principle of dhvani, or suggestion, lies in the possibility that a community may turn its gaze away from a question even when the light of truth is available. Draupadi's humiliation and the delay in treatment carry possibilities of pathos and indignation. Yet Rukhsana's joke about aubergines, Sanket's question about photographing, and the domestic time of cooking rice check the one-directional flow of emotion. This contrast between scenes benefits the composition.

Intertextual Achievement and Its Limit

The value of Chapter 15 is not that it simply assigns Draupadi's name to a modern character. It relates the central question of the ancient assembly to several disputes embodied in modern forms while keeping their concrete causes distinct. There is, however, a limit to this effect: in the light of Draupadi's incisive question, the contemporary characters' exact ethical language can appear even more polished, widening the gap between psychological naturalness and excessively well-ordered thought. Anita's questions, Salma's insistence and Naira's answers show an almost exemplary caution over error and evidence. This is a coherent artistic policy, but coherence alone cannot prove polyphony. Characters' inconsistency, mistakes, social fear and institutional constraints must occupy equal space in the text. Vikarna's limited influence in Chapter 16 puts this risk to a severe test.

Chapter 16 — The Silence After Vikarna

The Speaking of Dissent and the Unchanged Decision

The chapter's first scene shows Vikarna rising from his warm wooden seat in Hastinapura. Instead of answering Draupadi's question, the members of the assembly look to age, rank and personal connections. Vikarna stands without seeking permission from his brothers and raises the questions of Draupadi's consent and the rights Yudhishthira had already lost. Hearing his dissent, Karna answers in defence of the officially declared outcome of the game, but does not resolve the fundamental problem of consent. Even after Vikarna's protest has been entered, the principal decision about the wager remains intact. This is the chapter's central contradiction: a statement on the side of justice may survive in history without necessarily arresting institutional injustice at the moment it is made.

The psychological complexity of this episode emerges from Karna's and Vikarna's contrasting responses. The memory of Karna's earlier humiliation places his aggressive partisanship in context; it does not give him a moral acquittal. Vikarna understands the possible cost to his family of opposing his brothers; his courage is not turned into a mythological victory celebration. Nor does Draupadi immediately find consolation in the support of one man. Her question demands an answer from the entire assembly: personal sympathy and collective justice are different things.

Modern Register of Events: Correction of the Minutes, Not of Rights

When the draft minutes of the preceding meeting are read in Videhapur, Ruhani asks how the phrase 'unanimously agreed' can be justified when her name appears among those 'invited' but not among 'members with voting rights'. Amla Sarbaria presents evidence that three different misspellings and mismatches of her community name at different offices have caused applications from distinct families to be rejected as duplicate entries in one register. Sakib Abdal shows that the public donations ledger is separate from his private transport accounts; he is willing to disclose relevant receipts for public expenditure, but not his entire household account. In all three disputes the authenticity of written forms and the limits of the public right to examine them are at issue.

The correct version of Amla's name is entered on her application, but the old government register is not corrected. Sakib submits a copy of the public donations ledger, yet no final approval is given for the disputed transport charges. Ruhani has four situations separately recorded in the minutes: members' votes, objections by invitees, silence by members present, and absence of voting rights. The new draft records 'Present, but expressed no opinion'. This entry does not change the earlier vote, and the membership rules remain under review. The exact outcome in the register of events is not a changed decision but the preservation of counter-evidence against any later false declaration of unanimity.

Naira does not disclose Anita Chaupal's personal case to the meeting. She recognises that Anita's incorrect social classification and Amla's difficulties with spelling and duplicate registration are not the same problem. Nor is Sarita's death status a matter for this committee's vote. By the end, arrangements are being made to take different papers to three separate homes: Ruhani's minutes, Amla's application to correct her name, and Sakib's receipt for donations. None returns having secured the entirety of their rights, but each possesses an examinable trace of an incomplete claim.

Is Silence an Act, or the Absence of an Act?

The 'silence after Vikarna' in the title is not simply the emotionally charged stillness of the assembly. Its central question is who determines what silence means in words. Bhishma's silence before Draupadi, the risky silence of assembly members after Karna's rejoinder, Yudhishthira's lowered face and the court scribe's entry of the principal decision do not carry one moral meaning. Ruhani likewise asks how 'did not vote' could come to mean 'voted in favour'. The secretary's revised classification preserves silence not as consent but as an occurrence in which no opinion was expressed. This is the novel's narrative interpretation, not a claim that silence must have one universal meaning in every historical or legal context.

In narrative time the chapter returns three times to Hastinapura: Vikarna's speech at the beginning, concern over its effects and Draupadi's unanswered question in the middle (passages 21–23), and the darkness of the assembly in the final emotional return (33). The many passages of the present-day Videhapur meeting test this ancient resistance in institutional form. The centre of the alternating scenes is not an equivalence of victories, but the two times separating 'it was said' from 'it had an effect'. Vikarna's question does not produce immediate justice; Ruhani's objection has not yet produced voting rights. Despite different eras, institutions and entitlements, both raise a common question: without a record of dissent, how can the history of a decision be converted into the lie of unanimity?

Community Names, Donations and Labour: Three Forms of Counter-Evidence

The different spellings of Amla's name in three offices are no longer merely errors of orthography: they have caused the existence of distinct families to be treated as if merged into one entry. Along with 'correct one word' comes the demand to 'preserve the separate number of every household'. This criticises the evidence of personal lives as recorded through administrative naming. Correcting a label on a mobile phone will not automatically remove the error in an older rejection letter. Travel, copying and absence from paid work all contribute to the cost of correcting a name. At minimum, formal equality requires that the correct spelling of a community name should not erase the separate personhood of its members.

Sakib's donations ledger can be examined for public expenditure, but his private account does not automatically become public property. If his vehicle was used for community work, its rate, approval and receipts should be examined separately. If he obtained private benefit without donating, that requires investigation; the possibility is not, by itself, proof

of a crime. The earlier inspection of the outlet at the mouth of the channel remains incomplete; no excavation occurred without reliable measurement. Money spent on preparation must therefore be distinguished from payment for completed cleaning. The episode constructs the boundaries of workers' economic self-protection alongside civic publicity.

Champa's exhausted body sits on a bench in the veranda, not on the meeting stage; she wishes to express her view of the full draft of the minutes. The limits of Ruhani's claim to be a 'representative' return as an immediate question. Conversations about damp receipts, copying charges and a packet of sattu bought with one's own money preserve the time of labour and everyday humour between Amla and Sakib. Theoretical resistance is not separated from food, water and delayed travel. This is a significant artistic propriety of the scene.

Achievement in the Theory of Evidence, Possible Risks of Craft and the Ending's Suggestion

From a narratological standpoint, to infer 'everyone agreed' from 'everyone was present' is an unestablished generalisation. The opinion of a person present, the opportunity to express it, lawful voting rights and a vote actually cast are separate subjects. An additional classificatory distinction clarifies the ground for a valid inference, though it does not thereby prove the complete impartiality of the official register. The writer's achievement is to transform resistance into a written, testable and revisable fact, rather than leaving it as a matter of personal goodwill.

The chapter compares modern minutes with the records of the ancient assembly. The court scribe does not change the main page recording the victory, but adds the dissent at the margin; the Videhapur secretary leaves the decision unchanged while entering disagreement on a distinct line. The dramatic effect is subtle. Yet subtlety has a limit: argument and counter-argument repeatedly settle into the ideal categories of 'spoken', 'heard' and 'decided'. The reader encounters intense institutional debate, but the unpredictable crowd of a movement, unforeseen personal failure and the perspective of characters unable to speak receive less scope. This critical question must be tested in the novel's subsequent expansion. Here the inquiry remains confined to the evidence of Chapter 16.

The warm ashes of the final hearth echo the kitchen of the opening chapter. The declaration of Sarita's death remains uncorrected; Ruhani still lacks voting rights; Amla's original government register remains unchanged. But it has become slightly harder to describe what was 'silent' as consenting. At the level of suggestion, the heat that remains in the ashes tells us that the disappearance of visible flame is not the same as the

extinction of its warmth. This figurative possibility arises from the text; it does not predict a definite event to follow.

Sabha Parva / Ayodhya Kanda: A Combined Study of Chapters 13–16

Four Distinct Institutional Distances

Chapter 13 marks the distance between the living person's public speech and an actual amendment to the register of deaths. Chapter 14 distinguishes the nameplate identifying a representative from the rules governing her vote. Chapter 15 separates Draupadi's question from the assembly's accountability, Anita's misclassification from its source document, and Salma's patient-admission record from the time treatment began. Chapter 16 distinguishes recorded dissent from the power to alter the principal decision. All four distances can be brought under one dramatic proposition: after 'a voice has been heard', another procedure is still required before 'rights have changed'. But the subjects of proof, characters and administrative consequences of each must remain distinct. That separation is a fundamental discipline of criticism.

The extended temporal form of the narrative is also important. The sequence ceases to be uniform as the relief-list meeting involving Sarita and the committee meeting involving Ruhani on the next day lead to the entrance of Hastinapura in Chapter 15. That chapter alternates the ancient gambling scene with a modern home, hospital and office, then returns to the ancient assembly; Chapter 16 intercuts Vikarna's opposition with the revised modern minutes. Through this reconfiguration of two periods, the Mahabharata becomes more than an inscription above the chapter: it provides critical distance from present questions of accountability. The Ramayana's Ayodhya Kanda, however, functions in these chapters mainly as part of the larger division of the work. Direct narrative treatment of Kaikeyi or Bharata still awaits Chapter 17 and beyond. It would be mistaken to take resemblance between headings as proof that the Ramayana intertext has been fully established.

The Stages of Textual Evidence and the Complexity of Characters

The register of events distinguishes four levels: Sarita's signed protest, Ruhani's proposal to revise membership, Salma's and Anita's separate acknowledgments of inquiries, and the separate entries for members, invitees and silence in the minutes. None of these cancels the original error concerning rights on its own. If immediate physical presence, oral announcement, copies of receipts, the applicable rules and a final order are all given equal evidentiary weight, the novel's own narrative work is

damaged. This differentiation is an important point in source-conscious narratological criticism. Yet it would be equally improper to force the characters' experience into sterile categories. Shame at the utterance of a name, the weariness of age, fear of treatment, the fare required to reach work and the time of a meal are the social costs of establishing such evidence.

In feminist narratology, Ruhani's leadership is tested by Champa's personal consent; Anita seeks privacy while Salma wishes to complain under her own name; Draupadi asks the assembly for an answer beyond the comfort of a lone supporter; and Sarita walks onto the stage herself instead of being represented by her daughter. These differences are a concrete achievement of the text: it does not bind its female characters into one undifferentiated 'suffering community'. On the other hand, the rapid introduction of numerous social names enlarges the narrative's centre without immediately giving each a long, independent life-story. The critic must ask whether these people return in subsequent chapters through decisions, regret, change and disagreement, or remain merely examples in a single episode.

Assessment: Achievement and the Danger of Repetition

The strongest structural choice at the beginning of the Sabha Parva is that there is no victory celebration after Sarita's public appearance, Ruhani's reading of the rules or Vikarna's moral declaration. Characters return carrying acknowledgment slips, drafts, safeguarded copies and the next agenda. Rights remain matters of continuing struggle. The ancient Draupadi–Vikarna episode deepens the suggestion within this social process that writing 'consent' against silence is itself an exercise of power.

The principal danger is now becoming clearer: many characters promptly ask for sources, distinguish consent, withhold private information and identify stages of decision-making. Such caution lends the narrative world ethical stability, but the excess of one method of reasoning in every character's speech can reduce its polyphony. A second danger arises when every formal dispute ends in the promise of a subsequent meeting or an acknowledgment number, producing a sense of recurrent action. It would be wrong to extend this criticism to the entire novel, but the direct study of the first sixteen chapters makes it a legitimate question. The slow pace of social consequences and the pace of narrative are not the same thing. The reality of the former can be respected while the latter is examined independently as an artistic criterion.

Chapter 17 — Kaikeyi's Debt

The Palace Keys, the Elderly Maidservant and the Cost of a Promise: The Opening Scene

The chapter opens on the night before the coronation in Ayodhya. The watch-bell, flower baskets, pitchers and washed seats are visual preparations for royal authority. Yet focalisation settles not on an official declaration in the court but on three keys tied to Manthara's hand. The keys of the storeroom, the maidservants' veranda and the chest of medical supplies are small forms of administrative authority. Their weight is not simply the weight of iron; it is uncertainty over whose names and livelihoods will remain secure after a change in succession. The opening maidservant's question about the count of flowers and Manthara's reply about 'the names of those who count' establish simultaneously the social visibility of labour and the unequal consequences of political change.

The bandage over Kaikeyi's old wounded wrist marks the occasion on which she saved the king's life. The promise made then remained not merely a reward but an obligation deferred into the future. Manthara fears that the names of maidservants will be cut from the new arrangements, but she has no written official list. She remembers people's names through the order of knots in cloth. Kaikeyi asks her to distinguish what she has 'heard' from what she has 'seen'. The reader consequently has grounds neither to dismiss all of Manthara's apprehension as false nor to accept all of it as proved. Significantly, Manthara does not hide her fears about Bharata's future and her own old age behind the interests of the servants. Her open acknowledgment of self-interest makes her more complex than a mere puppet of conspiracy; it does not, however, render her proposed means morally innocent.

From the Vow to Exile: A Register of Events and Distinct Causes

The first concrete change is the arrival of uncertain news about transfers among servants amid preparations for the coronation. The second is Manthara's frank account of her mixed fears: dues owed to servants, Bharata's future and her own old age. Third, Kaikeyi, despite her affection for Rama and Bharata's absence, considers invoking the old boons. The fourth and decisive event is her demand before Dasharatha for two boons: Bharata's coronation and Rama's exile for fourteen years. The fifth change is Kaikeyi's admission of harm. She does not withdraw the boons but refuses to describe the decision as harmless. This chain of events does not establish the simplified justification that 'Rama was sent to the forest to protect the maidservants'. No necessary connection has been shown

between their genuine concerns and his exile; Kaikeyi herself cannot call it unquestionably necessary.

Narratively, Kaikeyi's choice comprises three distinct situations: her entitlement under an earlier promise, the political consequences of using that entitlement, and her moral responsibility for those consequences. A temporal distance separates Dasharatha's generosity on the day he made the promise from the incalculable price of fulfilling it. Kaikeyi defends her right to the promise, while acknowledging that Rama, Bharata, Kausalya, the citizens and others will bear its burden. The difference between 'the person who gives' and 'those made to carry the weight' persists into the chapter's final modern scene. A right may have a legitimate origin without every particular exercise of that right being justified. This is presented as the chapter's central argument, not as the Ramayana's undisputed original doctrine.

Manthara's limits as a source must also be recognised. Standing outside a doorway, she hears only fragments of the inner conversation, and does not risk making a complete meaning out of half a voice. At that moment the character herself accepts the boundary of her narrative knowledge. The narrator allows the reader to hear the inner dialogue while withholding it from Manthara. Through this unequal distribution, the reader knows more than the character. It is a finely arranged restriction of hearing, not a collective omniscience in which 'all characters know the same evidence'.

Asad Syed's School: Source Criticism of a Public Promise

At passage twenty, the narrative cuts to modern Videhapur. A notice at the school announces 'unanimity' and 'approval' by the committee, although the preceding minutes have already recorded Ruhani's dissent and the distinction concerning voting rights. Asad Syed takes the notice down, but does not tear it up and throw it away. He separately notes its issuer, issue date and what the school can actually verify. Affixing an outside statement to a school wall does not make the school the committee's decision-maker; nevertheless, the school's public standing can lend the statement credibility. Because of that double risk, Asad asks for an indication of source, differences between versions and a procedure for correction.

Naira explicitly separates three unfinished matters: Ruhani's objection is registered, but her voting rights undecided; Amla's application to correct her name has been accepted, but the original register is unchanged; Sarita's statement that she is alive has been recorded, but the death entry remains. Asad wants students and parents to understand these differences. The proposed school notice will separately identify the statement received from the committee, and a copy of the correct minutes will also be displayed once available. For the moment, however, only an acknowledgment

number for the request for a certified copy of the true minutes has been obtained. Neither ‘a new page was posted’ nor ‘the school overturned the old decision’ has occurred in this chapter.

Asad produces from his pocket two receipts for the expenses of copying and glue. Those small cash payments give the story’s documentary ethics material force: public verification is not an ideal task performed without labour. Someone’s body, time and pocket bear its costs. He wants to sign the correction request but refuses to assume that the school is responsible for all the defects of the originating notice. The connection with the ‘debt’ of Kaikeyi’s deferred promise lies here: one person makes a promise and others pay its costs. The penalties and responsibilities in the two episodes are nevertheless not identical.

Narrative Time, Focalisation and Intertextual Propriety

The prolonged ancient night in Ayodhya and the modern school’s day-long procedure are arranged in sequence. At the end, an Ayodhya morning (passage 34) and a Videhapur night (35) bring the two temporal strands face to face. This parallel time does not create a fixed metaphor in which ‘Kaikeyi equals a particular modern woman’. Asad demands no royal boon; he examines the source of a statement already circulated. Naira is no king, but an applicant within an uncertain government procedure. The shared structure is the difference between a word that confers authority and its actual consequences, not equivalence between historical institutions. The suffocation of Ayodhya’s inner chamber, the papers on a school wall, rice cooking in the kitchen and Urmila’s nighttime carrying of loads place grand decisions beside the unremitting tasks of ordinary lives.

The narrator reveals the private anxieties of several figures: Manthara’s admission of self-interest, Kaikeyi’s uncertain reasons, Asad’s care over a public statement and Naira’s act of writing down a reference number. Focalisation is not fixed upon one individual; it shifts with the episode. The story nevertheless repeatedly writes out the boundaries of evidence —‘the committee has not yet given permission’, ‘the original government register has not been corrected’—to prevent unwarranted conclusions. The benefit is attention to the fine grain of history; the limitation is that characters’ complex experiences sometimes flow into passages of argument. Kaikeyi’s inner conflict, in particular, receives remarkably lucid language. Such lucidity helps the novel’s self-critical project but may reduce the natural scope for fear, impulse and the unexpected inconsistency of error.

Narratology, Suggestion and Critical Judgment

It is invalid to infer from an announcement of ‘unanimity’ that every person present lawfully agreed, because the distinctions between

membership, participation, silence, objections and voting rights have already been established. The school's seal cannot by itself enhance the authority of the committee's decision. The speaker behind verbal testimony, the occasion of utterance and the scope of authority thus become matters for examination. In Kaikeyi's story, the existence of an earlier vow is one fact; the necessity and justice of exercising it in a particular way are separate propositions to be established. Manthara's fear that the servants will be displaced may be a genuinely examinable apprehension. It does not establish that their protection is impossible without Rama's exile.

The keys, bandage, two lines of a notebook, noticeboard and receipts form distinct groups of symbolic objects. In the closing scene Urmila refuses to carry another bundle at night unless the additional hours are recorded. The weight of that small economic disagreement can be understood without equating it with the far greater harm of Kaikeyi's demand. This is the chapter's considered achievement: the grand royal language of an obligation owed descends into the minute accounts of working lives. Its main limitation is that competing political options receive only limited practical examination. Although the tragic consequences of Kaikeyi's decision have been outlined, the multiple voices of resistance within royal consultation have not been fully opened. The next chapter will give independent time to the labour left in the household, but that cannot exonerate the royal decision made here.

Chapter 18 — Urmila's Night

The Narrative Centre of Lives "Left Behind" in Ancient Ayodhya

The chapter begins with the sound of pitchers being filled in the royal palace at Ayodhya. Behind the celebrated departure of Rama for the forest, the small routines of life—Kausalya's medicines, Sumitra's care and the elderly maidservant's rest—come forward. One chest can be packed for Lakshmana's journey, but no one wishes to become the 'owner' of the second chest containing the household work left behind. The design of two chests is more than a simple metaphor. It asks how narrative burdens are distributed: the hero's decision to depart acquires public moral prestige, while the time of those providing care can remain unnamed. Urmila does not deny the necessity of Lakshmana's departure; she asks whose needs will continue here.

Shrutakirti's joke about roasted grain and jaggery, Mandavi's limits in managing the household, the elderly servant's difficulty seeing properly at night and Sumitra's participatory choices prevent Urmila from being only an abandoned wife. 'I do not want a boon of sleep. I want the nights that

belong to me': this sentence is at the centre of the narrative departure from familiar versions. It must not be treated as an established incident in the popular story of exchanged sleep. In this novel Urmila asks for the material right to rest. Mandavi's question—if responsibility for work is given, how much authority comes with it?—opens up the institutional aspect of Urmila's reckoning. Sumitra participates in decisions about her own care; an elderly mother is not merely its passive recipient.

Lakshmana does not offer the false assurance that 'I shall put everything right'. Nor is Urmila merely a figure of resentment: her anger, love, organisation and personal pleasure remain distinct. In the last return to the ancient sequence, she speaks to a companion of the delight of songs, flowers and sewing a small garment with her own hands. Where the heroine might have been made an obligatory icon of sacrifice, the story identifies the remaining right to personal interests. Yet the dialogues of this ancient household frequently approach the precise vocabulary of contemporary labour rights. This historical distance should be read as a condition of narrative reconstruction, not as verbatim dialogue taken from an ancient source.

Night Transport in Videhapur: What Actually Changed?

The modern sequence begins in passage eleven. A vehicle has arrived to carry the hospital's linen, but the letter describes only 'day transport'. Urmila stipulates separate recording of the additional hours at night and of three kinds of linen. Naira helps her read the paper but does not speak the conditions in Urmila's place. Urmila opens her private workers' register and creates separate lines for time, bundles, arrival time and 'payment outstanding'. The driver, too, asks that his hours be recorded. Urmila agrees but refuses to add his time under her own name. Justice for workers in this scene is not an uncosted moral victory for one side; it is the recognition of different measures of everyone's labour.

By telephone the hospital's night entrance agrees to record the receipt and count of the linen, but says that approval of wages rests with the contractor. On arrival, the changed storage location turns out not to have been communicated to the laundry; once again the workers might have borne the blame for delay. Urmila has the actual handover time recorded but refuses to place her thumbprint while the payment field remains empty. She eventually obtains a copy of the acknowledgment marked 'Payment undecided'. The linen was delivered; the nighttime hours were recorded; the money was not paid. To compress these three outcomes into a single word such as 'success' would diminish the struggle present in the primary text.

Urmila's body is the real basis of these accounts: aching arms, sweat on the forehead, unfinished sleep, brackish water, bread and leftover vegetables. Had the story treated her merely as a symbol of a certificate, it would remain incomplete. Sarita bringing warm water, the actual weight of loading bundles onto the vehicle and Urmila's final declared wish 'to sleep' establish that the ethics of paperwork cannot replace bodily rest. This is why, in the final morning, Naira does not reopen either the microphone and death-entry question or the notebook containing twenty-seven names. Her decision not to advance the principal mystery needlessly gives a seemingly secondary labour narrative its own decisive closure.

Saraswati Thakur's Skill, Daughter and the Small Economy of Work

Outside the hospital, Saraswati Thakur earns a modest livelihood by arranging and cutting hair and providing small services to patients' relatives and attendants. Her bag contains a comb, scissors, clean bandages, thread and receipts. Customers who price the two moments when scissors are actually moving often fail to count the time needed for preparation, cleanliness, seating and fetching water. Saraswati's practice is structurally parallel to Urmila's counting of bundles: the visible 'finished task' in an occupation differs from its invisible preparation costs. Her professional evidence, however, consists of her own fee receipts, not copies of Urmila's hospital accounts.

Saraswati's daughter expresses the wish to attend a training class. Her mother says that the fees and travel expenses must be considered, but does not order her to remain in the family occupation. The sentiment that knowing how to shorten somebody's hair does not confer the right to cut short everyone's dreams for a lifetime is a light, sharp satire on compulsory hereditary occupation. The daughter tries to study beneath a dim streetlight because domestic duties will leave her with less time. Here labour rights are not merely the wages of today; they also concern the distribution of study time to the next generation. Saraswati's local recognition for her work and her daughter's freedom of choice both matter; neither devalues the other.

Champa's brief appearance at the hospital entrance advances an ethical boundary that becomes important in the next chapter. Noticing the privacy of a patient's relatives, she says that not every piece of news is meant for everyone. Urmila answers that Champa herself will decide when to speak about herself. This is not necessarily a prolepsis—a definite prediction of the future. Once a private message becomes public in the following chapter, readers may interpret this moment anew. The distinction between subtle foreshadowing and certain prior knowledge must be preserved.

Narrative Time, Duration, Focalisation and Rasa

The story passes from the ancient morning before departure into the modern sequence of night labour and its consequences (passages 11–27), returns briefly to an ancient evening (28–29), and closes with sleep on a modern morning (30–31). This segmented rhythm of narrative time is not a symmetrical arrangement of actual hours but an artistic duration shaped by the right to rest. Time written in Urmila's register differs from time experienced within the story: a delay may occupy a single line on paper, but for the body it expands into the experience of a long night. Through that difference, narrative time becomes a criticism of how lived time is classified.

The third-person narrator approaches Urmila's ancient anxieties, the bodily discomfort of present-day labour and Saraswati's choices concerning her daughter. The internal focus does not remain with one person. The combination of pathos and humour—Shrutakirti's jaggery, Sarita's 'wedding procession' joke about bread, and the final answer 'to sleep'—prevents uninterrupted lamentation. The suggestion here is not an accusation against an absent hero, but recognition of the divided time of workers who are present. Nevertheless, the women of the palace sometimes discuss the division of labour in such orderly terms that their dialogue resembles a modern social-policy paper. Both the living contemporary reactivation of a classical intertext and the risk of anachronistic simplification are present. Criticism must record them together.

Examination of Evidence, Achievement and What Remains Incomplete

The acknowledgment proves that the linen reached its destination; it does not approve the wages. A worker's private register is supporting evidence for a claim about time, not the contractor's official confirmation of payment. A printed order referring to daytime work cannot erase work done at night, but the precise amount of additional remuneration cannot be established through moral insistence alone. Because of this evidentiary discipline, Urmila's victory is limited, real and open to later review. Bodily sleep is an immediate achievement; economic payment remains a question for the future.

The artistic achievement is that the minor mythological subplot of 'the wife left at home' acquires a self-sufficient ethical narrative world. Through Saraswati's occupation, her daughter and the hospital arrangements, the modern Urmila becomes more than a counterpart of the ancient one. A possible weakness is equally clear: the domestic characters of the Ramayana speak almost like expert formulators of general principles. There is relatively little room for silence under pressure,

wrong decisions or self-interested resistance within existing relations of labour. Yet Urmila's final sleep is a quiet and dramatic resolution in contrast to this verbal abundance. It should be understood not as complete liberation for workers, but as one night's independently won outcome.

Chapter 19 — Champa's Message

From Private Desire to Improper Exposure at a Public Meeting

The chapter begins with Champa's extremely limited rest, her mother's medicines, fares and the accounting of working hours. Only after these material responsibilities comes a private message written on a phone about taking time off: going to the market with a beloved person, eating hot jalebis and sitting together without anyone watching over them. The narrator does not frame this wish as a shameful secret of conduct; it represents future pleasure that Champa hopes to claim from time earned through her own labour. Ruhani gives an acknowledgment of the earlier objection concerning the privacy of medical treatment. Champa makes clear that acknowledgment does not mean acceptance of the demand. The brief exchange in which Rukhsana lets a person add more salt to their own serving of rice becomes an unforced practical image of personal choice within collective rules, although its fuller significance derives from the chapter's drama.

At a meeting reviewing public expenditure, applications for assistance and the public budget lie on the same table. Champa brings only a receipt for travel expenses, not her mother's private treatment papers. An unknown person places in the chairperson's hands an edited version of Champa's private message. A line from the middle has been removed; the recipient's name is printed incompletely; the message expressing a desire is read aloud as an indication that assistance has been misused. At that moment the narrative presents the injury not merely through laughter in the assembly, but through Champa's sensation of her body going cold and her shoulders stiffening. Public humiliation has not established irregularity in expenditure on government medicines. It has only brought an intimate utterance before the gathering without authorisation.

Register of Events: What Was Stopped and What Was Not

The first change is that an unauthorised, edited message begins to be read publicly. The second is Champa's standing up herself and demanding that the reading stop, followed by the chairperson's initial refusal. The third is Ruhani's supportive intervention and Champa's clear separation of her private wish from the conditions governing public assistance. The fourth is Champa's signed application containing three demands: further reading or distribution must cease; the available copy must be preserved for examination rather than destroyed; and the minutes must record not the absence of dissent but her express objection. The fifth is a procedural change: receipt of the application, cessation of any further reading at that meeting, sealing of the copy left on the table and submission of the

copying-register's serial number. Yet the return of all copies previously circulated among those present is not established. How the original message leaked, who edited it and through whom it reached the platform remain unresolved.

Instead of demanding that the stolen copy immediately be torn up and destroyed, Champa asks that it be preserved for investigation. This choice leaves open the possibility of turning the hostile object into evidence. Yet the administrative act of putting a publicity copy into an envelope does not itself restore confidentiality: numerous copies may already have circulated through phones and duplicating machines. Naira hears part of the page read on the platform; she has not seen the original telephone message. Champa leaves open the possibility of providing selected portions to an authorised investigator for comparison, but refuses any obligation to reveal the entirety of her private conversation even to a friend. The actual consequence of her right here is not public seizure of the original phone, but her authority to decide the limits within which evidence will be shared.

Rahina's Copy Register, Karim's Dholak and the Incomplete Chain of Provenance

Karim Dafali receives a proposal to write an election campaign song using lines from Champa's message. He sings an older political song, but refuses to turn Champa's personal words into material for ridicule. His decision that the dholak will not be played does not cancel the community's right to music; it distinguishes subject matter, remuneration and consent. Karim preserves the proposal slip without initiating a campaign in Champa's name or without her permission. He is not paid the dholak-hire fee: the financial cost of his ethically sound decision also remains on the accounts. Thus Karim does not become an inert emblem of idealism; he acquires the specific predicament of a working musician.

Rahina Thakurai runs a small copying and binding business. Her register records the time of reproduction, page counts and serial numbers; it does not make her an omniscient witness to the papers' actual origins or to the offender's identity. Although the page circulating in the meeting hall resembles paper used in her business, she does not claim identical provenance merely from identical size. Her decision not to reveal a recipient's private address without authorised procedure, alongside her willingness to produce relevant register entries during an inquiry, maintains the limits of her trade. Its particular importance lies in recognising that a reproduction worker is not the proprietor of a document's truth, yet is answerable for the accounting of its manufacture.

This is a subtle documentary ethics that cannot properly be compressed into a single easy formula of archival 'truth'.

Karim's unplayed dholak and Rahina's safeguarded register become two forms of restraint in expression. One prevents the humiliating repetition of a private story; the other preserves numbers needed to investigate how a document was reproduced. Neither character appropriates the right to represent Champa. This accords with the central character's autonomy, but it must also be remembered that the political motivations of the unnamed young men who made Karim the proposal are not fully developed. It would be improper to invent accusations about the source of the campaign.

Evidence, Consent and the Narrow Limits of the Right to Narrate

In a narratologically consistent examination, the printed copy read on the platform is one object; the original phone message is another; the origin of the cut-and-edited version is a third question; and permission to read it publicly is a fourth. 'The message was originally written' does not entail 'permission existed to read it in the meeting'. Nor is there an invariable connection between 'wanting to eat jalebis' and 'misusing government expenditure for treatment'. A majority of spectators cannot generate ownership of anyone's private message. The story, however, does not claim that a complete legal decision has already established against whom, under which provisions, liability lies. Kabir explains only the procedure of a possible complaint; Champa has the words 'the right to seek legal remedy is reserved' entered in writing.

The story's ethical importance lies in the moment Champa reads her own written petition aloud. Ruhani is a witness to it, not automatically her representative. Defending her right to a private life within the assembly, Champa also chooses when next to speak with the person she loves: she does not immediately send the entire story of the injury over the phone. Her wish to converse with that person survives the resistance to an unauthorised disclosure; this prevents humiliation from becoming a one-dimensional definition of her life. Sarita warns Naira not to fill an empty information field with conjecture. Naira records 'original source unknown' and 'objection received' in the register, leaving the space for identifying the culprit blank. Here emptiness is not an ornamental mystery but an authenticated limit of knowledge.

Narrative Rhythm, Linguistic Contradiction and the Limits of Criticism

The narrative organisation moves from a private message in the morning through a community meeting, an outside copying shop and the shelter to the night at home. At intervals the reader encounters Champa's bodily

distress and the social reverberations of her humiliation. The word ‘jalebi’ first names private pleasure, next becomes a device of ridicule, and finally offers Rukhsana’s prospect of food as consolation. Through this recurrence, the word’s meaning shifts with its context; its resonant effect is more complicated than one-track symbolism. The sequence of compassion, anger and humour resists reducing the injured woman to an inert personality defined only by suffering.

Achievement: the public narrative authority of a female character, the testing of knowledge, and independent roles for folk music and copying labour are incorporated into one incident without fabricating the source’s identity. Limitation: in an extremely sensitive assembly, numerous characters immediately respond in clear, well-organised ethical and procedural language. The social psychology behind the humiliating laughter, the prolonged inward time of the speechless Champa and the chairperson’s basis of power are relatively underdeveloped. The chairperson’s final prohibition is a limited administrative act, not conclusive evidence of ethical transformation. The narrative’s success lies precisely in laying bare this incompleteness: the source of the private message remains unidentified, while Champa’s private life still belongs to her.

Chapter 20 — Premature Publication

From the Wish to Correct an Injustice to a Harmful Decision: The Plot’s Turn

Chapter 20 does not retain Naira as an ethically unassailable centre. After Champa’s meeting she is in haste to halt injustice, and she also senses the urgency, in the public interest, of removing the danger posed by the blocked drainage channel. Mahesh Mandal formerly worked on a temporary basis recording the times at which vehicles entered the warehouse. He saw when vehicles travelled and which road they took; he did not see what they carried, whether a crime was committed or for what purpose. His oral repetition of the information establishes this evidentiary limitation from the outset. Mahesh chooses to meet under an open shed and requires the protection of his family, especially his daughter’s route to school, as a prior condition.

The consent in Mahesh’s letter was restricted: the committee could be informed so that a general inspection of the road behind the warehouse might be undertaken, but details of public testimony, work schedules capable of identifying him, or the family’s location were not to be revealed until protection was secured. Naira stops at the first sentence giving permission and, although she reads the final prohibitory sentence, does

not give it sufficient weight. A colleague advises the appropriate precaution: first publish only the discrepancy between public maps and a request for an inspection of the site. Fearing official delay, Naira posts details indicating the time and occupational identity. The ethical gravity of this decision lies not in the central protagonist's ignorance but in her disregard of a condition she knows.

The published statement does not contain Mahesh's name, yet the combination 'behind the western warehouse', 'repair work' and 'former employee' gives those familiar with the locality a means of identifying the source. In the second stage of circulation, the phrase 'former employee' threatens to become 'the man who disclosed the secret'. Naira tries to prevent immediate accusations, but copies, screenshots and verbal elaborations of the original post are already in circulation. The chapter gives no certain conclusion as to who actually identified Mahesh or inflicted physical harm; nevertheless, a telephone call from an old acquaintance, the risk attached to the route home and immediate fears about safety are directly reported responses. 'The name was not printed' is not adequate evidence of confidentiality here.

Register of Events: Five Distinct Levels of Actual Change

(1) Naira receives Mahesh's written information subject to conditions. (2) Without sufficient permission she publishes details bearing on his identity in the town's digital group: this is an action completed, not merely contemplated. (3) Mahesh describes the danger over the telephone and Naira acknowledges her mistake. (4) Naira removes the post, issues a correction and separately safeguards the original draft, the published version, the correction and the permission document; yet she cannot erase earlier screenshots or public memory. (5) Mahesh's family begins to consider alternatives for safe travel and accommodation, while Kabir explains possible procedures; official protection remains unconfirmed. The notice that the drainage channel will be resurveyed at a subsequent meeting belongs to a separate official sequence. The document does not identify Naira's post as its cause. It would be wrong to compress these five stages into a single claim such as 'the matter was resolved after the post was deleted' or 'the post made the authorities act'.

Mahesh asks Naira not to visit his house for several days, so that his family's crisis is not transformed into a social obligation to console Naira's guilt. She complies. Mahesh's wife does not treat the possible arrangements for leaving home as simple proof of consent; she explains that leaving is not easy. Together the daughter, mother and Mahesh prepare a list of possible routes. The people endangered retain narrative authority in this small family meeting. 'Protection' is not a gift bestowed from outside by

the protagonist; it remains unfinished work that includes the affected family's decisions.

Chandra Badi's Remuneration: A Parallel Economy of the Publication Error

Chandra Badi demands her fee with a written contract specifying three songs and time for rehearsals. The office attempts to exclude her from payment rules by calling her a 'guest'. The contract specifies rehearsal time, but leaves the box for travel fares empty. Her instrument case is torn, and a fellow singer helps to stitch its strap. These material details show that before the public pleasure of song come the labour of equipment, journeys, time and repairs. Chandra's declaration that she sells her art, not the history of her body, shares Champa's concern for privacy, yet her economic claim regarding labour is independent.

After Naira deletes the post, two men ask Chandra about Mahesh's secret whereabouts because she travels from village to village. Chandra makes clear that occupational mobility is not a licence for covert surveillance. The office has not paid the entire amount, but has acknowledged the outstanding sum in writing. Chandra preserves two copies of the receipt; the financial result is thus limited. Through this episode Naira understands Mahesh's conditions anew: failing to read a worker's permission or an artist's contract in full, then imposing one's own decision upon it, are different but comparable forms of encroachment. The comparison does not establish causal equivalence; it concerns the general question of who controls the terms of an agreement.

Inference, Unknown Risks and Legitimate Levels of Evidence

Mahesh saw vehicles travel at particular times. 'Vehicles travelled' does not necessarily entail 'they carried illegal goods'. The difference between two municipal maps had already prompted a demand for investigation; it does not make every warehouse employee a criminal. Mahesh himself stresses these limits. The fault in Naira's digital publication is not merely that a statement might be factually false: combining plausible details can also produce an unsafe identification. Narratologically, the episode offers a fruitful means of distinguishing proposition, reason and qualifying condition: an entry recording vehicle times can be preliminary evidence for further inquiry, but does not prove a criminal purpose.

The notice about resurveying from Aditi's office follows independent original applications—Gomati's request for a site inspection, Tara's markings and Hira's water measurements. The notice does not attribute the decision to Naira's post. The novel thus itself blocks the consequentialist proposition, 'It was necessary to take the risk because the

administration moved.' There is a crucial opposition here: the safety of public drainage is a collective good; danger to a witness's family is an individual injury. Both concerns are real, but the necessity of the former does not nullify dissent concerning the latter. Naira's error was not an inability to choose the difficult side of a moral dilemma; it was to violate a stated condition and afterwards seek to justify the violation through conjecture.

Padma's arrival prepares the ground for a later audio examination. She explains that when the microphone was switched off at Champa's meeting, whose voice belonged to whom, and which portions of Mahesh's statement were cut cannot be decided without the original chronology. The narratological implication is twofold: cutting the sequence of the original message altered Champa's meaning, and cutting the decisive conditional sentence in Naira's post altered Mahesh's safety. Padma's examination, however, has not yet been performed; what exists here is only an invitation and a cautious proposal. This chapter gives no grounds for claiming that a complete forensic verification of the audio has taken place.

Narrative Time, Focalisation and Digital Repetition

The opening sequence of 'morning', 'afternoon', 'evening' and 'night' compresses Naira's decision into a single day. Posting is a singular occurrence, but the circulation of its copies opens an iterative and indefinitely extended future. The text does not count the number of shares. The possibility of numerous distributed versions from one identifiable original is the social dimension of narrative frequency. Naira can remove one original post, not the reader's memory or screenshots on other phones. By this irreversibility of time, the story gives concrete form to the responsibility associated with premature publication.

At first the narrator presents Naira's urgent inferences from within her perspective, then develops in distinct locations Mahesh's fear, his wife's domestic insecurity, Chandra's economic rights, Sanket's question and the limitations of Padma's inquiry. The focalised consciousness does not remain imprisoned in Naira's guilt. Mahesh's wife and Sanket, in particular, refuse Naira a monopoly on ethical narration. Sanket's question —'You ask me for permission to take my picture; why not apply the same rule to Mahesh?'—is the chapter's self-critical turn. Compared with the preceding chapters, Naira's mistake is a genuinely adverse event in her character development: she becomes not merely an investigator of wrongdoing but also its cause.

The unfinished note of Chandra's instrument and Naira's truncated sentence form the closing sound of the chapter. Remove half a line, or cut

away the breath before or after a note, and meaning changes—just as removing a condition from a document changes the meaning of consent. The thin stream running through the drainage channel recalls a real material risk: safe measurements of water are necessary, but making someone's home unsafe is not required to obtain them. The final sentence, though, is also an overt ethical interpretation supplied by the narrative; there is tension between the openness of a symbol and an explicit statement of principle.

Literary Achievement, Critical Objections and a Limited Conclusion

This chapter subjects the habitual ethical caution of the first nineteen chapters to its own test. Naira has repeatedly learned about sources, acknowledgments, consent and the limits of publication; here she fails to comply and commits an error. Genuine adversity thereby enters the development of her character. Mahesh's independent voice, the different risks faced by his wife and daughter, and Chandra's authority over her contract prevent one protagonist's remorse from swallowing everyone's story. Yet readers may find the conversion of the heroine's mistake into a 'lesson' rather rapid: the long-term consequences for Mahesh's life remain uncertain, whereas Naira clearly admits her fault within the same day. Should later chapters fail to develop actual danger, the rebuilding of trust and the affected family's differing reactions, the dramatic weight of so serious a fault may diminish. For now this is only a question for critical inquiry, not a verdict about the future.

A further limitation lies in the exceptionally neat alignment of a document's final sentence, the cues to digital identification and the moral conclusion. This conceptual clarity is useful, but the uncontrolled social psychology of circulating digital gossip, pressure from local authority and the protagonist's unexpected rationalisations of her first error might have been explored further. Even so, the chapter achieves something uncommon: it exposes a publication made in the name of the public good to criticism by counter-evidence, and does not allow 'my intentions were good' to erase wrongdoing. The corrective statement has been published; the source's security remains unsettled; the circulation of the post cannot be wholly recalled. That is the actual ending.

Sabha Parva / Ayodhya Kanda: Comparative Narratological Study of Chapters 17–20

The Promise of Rights, the Weight of Decisions and the Time of Error

Kaikeyi's invocation of an old boon, Urmila's written record of night hours, the unauthorised reading of Champa's private message and the

violation of Mahesh's conditional letter are four events occupying distinct evidentiary positions. In the first, the giver of a promise and the person who bears its consequences are different. In the second, the directly worked hours and acceptance of liability for payment are distinct. In the third, the truth of the message and permission to read it publicly are separate. In the fourth, consent to a general inspection and permission to publish evidence capable of identifying a witness are different things. In each case, the leap from 'something has been written' to 'the right to every use has been granted' becomes a focus of criticism. Yet the resemblance does not make the four events identical in their legal or moral consequences. Rama's exile, Urmila's unpaid dues, Champa's humiliation and the threat to Mahesh's security represent differing degrees of adversity.

Narrative Voice and the Distribution of Ancient and Modern Material

Chapter 17 constructs a movement from Ayodhya to the school and then a return between Ayodhya and Videhapur. Chapter 18 produces a two-stranded temporal arrangement that alternates Ayodhya, hospital, Ayodhya and hospital. Chapters 19 and 20 contain no independent ancient scenes; the great configuration of the Ayodhya Kanda continues as the background to their moral questions. The epic intertext thus works at varying densities, not as the mechanical enforcement of a single rule. The dialogue of Kaikeyi, Manthara, Urmila, Shrutakirti, Mandavi, Sumitra and Lakshmana approaches modern conceptual vocabulary. This is an explicit choice of rewriting, not a direct translation of historical literature.

Independent Subplots of Social Labour and the Need for Critical Care

Manthara's keeping of keys, Asad's charges for copying notices, Urmila's hours of washed clothing, Saraswati's hairdressing supplies, Karim's dholak payment, Rahina's copying work and Chandra's singing contract are not merely a 'list of society's occupations'. When these workers independently sustain their claims about prices, preparation, evidence and decision-making, their subplots acquire narrative existence. Yet many characters quickly pronounce apt ethical maxims. The private inconsistencies, attachments, fears and differing registers of speech among several social characters have not yet been sufficiently developed. If a common authorised ethical vocabulary replaces the independent speech of every character, the claim to polyphony will be weakened. How much opportunity is actually given to the conversations of artists, labourers and copyists is the pertinent question here.

From Narratological Perspective to Socially Valid Knowledge

The existence of a promise does not prove the propriety of its purpose; a receipt of acknowledgment is not payment; the authenticity of an original private message does not constitute permission for its public reading; an observed vehicle schedule is not proof of illegal goods; and advance notice of an official resurvey does not demonstrate that Naira's dangerous publication succeeded. These five distinctions are better understood as a sequence of narrative evidence. Without asserting that the novel has established a complete formal inference according to a theory of knowledge, we can identify the inadequacy of reasons, the limits of context and conclusions that cannot be inferred from its evidentiary objects. Naira's mistake in Chapter 20, in particular, does not abolish her grasp of evidentiary method; it makes the ethical responsibility for distributing evidence applicable to her own conduct.

Clear Outcomes of Plot Development and Questions for Further Inquiry

At the end of Chapter 17 an acknowledgment number is obtained for accurate minutes of the school meeting, while the original injustice persists. In Chapter 18 the clothing arrives and hours of night labour are entered, but the wages remain unpaid. In Chapter 19 the private message is no longer read at that day's meeting; a copy is preserved and its source remains unknown. In Chapter 20 Naira removes her improper publication and issues a correction, but Mahesh's safety remains unsettled. Across these episodes the story repeatedly returns to the distance between an institution's 'receipt' and an actual 'outcome'. This recurrence makes administrative time credible; it also risks a monotonous dramatic rhythm if every chapter closes on the same sequence of caution, receipt and incompletion. Naira's consequential error in Chapter 20 is a significant challenge to that monotony. Further analysis must ask how fully the long-term consequences of the damaging decision enter the causal development of personal relations, housing, communal trust and drainage.

Chapter 21 — Whose Voice?

The Physical Arrangement of Listening and the Ethical Proposition of the Opening

The first scene is set in the western room of the community building. The whir of the fan, the red light of the recording device, the window shutter and the directions in which chairs face are not mere furnishings. Padma first rearranges the seating so that the speaker's face remains in the light. She insists that people who read lips or ask questions through sign-based

communication must also be able to participate in the responses. Through this small material arrangement, the chapter defines 'voice' not simply as sound audible to the ear, but as a publicly accessible situation of translation, visibility and the ability to respond. The very first change in the narrative is physical: an expert seated behind a table is not made the centre of public relations; barriers between speakers and listeners are removed.

Just before and after this scene, preparations are under way for the annual event combining public reading, open accounts and songs. The outlet for smoke from Rukhsana's stove, Hamida's songbook, unpaid wages and the water register enter a common public space. The organised 'cultural' programme cannot be kept apart from archival scrutiny: the platform that bestows credit for entertainment must also be used to read the accounts of labour. This is the chapter's decisive feature of time and place. Yet two short audio clips have been circulating before the event and have already shaped people's judgments; not everyone possesses the original recording, but everyone is declaring a 'complete verdict'. The initial tension lies here: the circulation of one fragment has seized control of the entire causal sequence of the story.

Naira herself admits that her previous publication violated the conditions of Mahesh's permission. Padma's answer—that Naira's guilt is not evidence either—establishes both the progress of her character and a discipline of criticism. Remorse cannot substitute for the injured person's voice. Naira draws three columns in her notebook, 'statement', 'inference' and 'permission', without writing anyone's name in advance. Through this material act of writing, the consequences of Chapter 20's wrongful publication have been converted into narrative conduct, not merely a sermon about self-education. Whether she will maintain these limits in the future is not decided by this single scene.

Meaning Reversed by a Cut Sentence: Register of Events in the First Audio Recording

The first sequence of events is established as follows: (1) the secretary brings two phones and a memorandum; (2) a circulating clip appears to join the phrases 'read it before everybody' and 'Champa's private matter'; (3) people have already taken this join to mean that Ruhani ordered the reading of Champa's private message; (4) Padma asks whether these two fragments belong to the same sentence; and (5) after receiving limited permission from the chairperson, the original office audio file is played on the office device itself. In this progression, possession of audio material, permission to examine it and the right to distribute it publicly remain separate stages. The fact that the device belongs to the office does not make the recording

automatically innocent of alteration. Padma herself acknowledges the need to compare its origins and contents with the minutes.

In the original file Ruhani first demands that the ‘rules’ for taking up private papers be read publicly. She then states clearly that Champa’s ‘private matter’ must not be read before the public. The circulating fragment cuts away the beginning of the first statement and the negation from the second. Consequently, what in the original utterance protects privacy becomes, in the edited fragment, apparent support for invading it. This is not simply a missing summary; it is a reversal of the construction of meaning. Weariness on Ruhani’s face and the opening of Champa’s clenched hands connect the episode with the bodily reactions of the injured parties. These reactions, however, are not technical proof of the editing; they show its ethical effect.

The original recording contains approximately half a minute of indistinct silence because a worker moved away from the microphone. Padma marks that blank interval on paper; she does not invent the missing words. The secretary’s minutes record separately the demand to read the rules and the objection to reading Champa’s private matter, but the secretary cannot remember why one word was crossed out in pencil. Rather than hiding these two omissions, the narrative makes them limits of the archive. Comparison with the available evidence demonstrates that a specific allegation is inconsistent with the full sequence. It does not establish the editor’s identity or purpose, nor the integrity of every part of the recording. Padma restrains Naira’s haste and accepts only the measured statement that the specific accusation should be suspended.

Audible Evidence and an Unproven Agent: A Narratological Perspective

Here the instruments of direct perception include, alongside the ear, the device, context, written minutes, chronological sequence and the speaker’s answers. That an edited fragment was heard is a matter of auditory perception. Turning it into the conclusion ‘Ruhani wanted Champa’s private affairs made public’ is an inference; the grounds of that inference are defeated when the full sentence is restored. ‘The voice sounded similar’ and ‘the meaning is identical’ are two different assertions. The sequence preserved in the original office file is important counter-evidence against one specific charge; the file’s external provenance, completeness and integrity nevertheless remain subjects for independent examination. The source text itself demands this caution. It would therefore be improper to say that a wholly formal proposition has been proven by the narrative. What the story offers is a practical examination of the limits of a reason and of defeating evidence.

Mahesh's voice in the second audio clip cannot be matched with the meeting recording because Mahesh never spoke from the platform at that meeting. A public interpretation added to the clip, such as 'all vehicles travelling at night are illegal', cannot be established through examination of the first recording. Padma makes this separation explicit. Because of Mahesh's security conditions, Naira refrains from publishing the second fragment. Here 'not writing' is a negative, yet actual, ethical act. Ruhani's objection is equally important: silence everywhere is not a solution; one must ask who possesses the right to silence. The narrative does not therefore produce a universal prescription for muteness; it searches for a balance between personal choice and evidence concerning the public good.

Cultural Labour, the Meaning of Song and the Public Character of the Archive

Hamida Miriyasin is asked to alter two lines of a folk song to provoke laughter at Champa's humiliation. If she refuses to sing, she will be charged with stopping the 'village's song'; if she sings, she becomes a participant in the insult. At the same time, her previously agreed fee has been halved in the name of 'traditional service'. Speaking against her humiliation, Champa does not seek permission to deprive Hamida of her livelihood. Within this triangle the question 'whose voice?' takes the form of three distinct rights: the singer's choice of words, the injured person's privacy and the worker's remuneration. Padma says that payment and permission to use the song must be treated separately.

The incomplete water-use lease, Chandra's remuneration, Rukhsana's cooking work and Padma's fee for facilitating signed communication occupy different columns in a single open account displayed on the platform. A budget line exists for Padma's services, but no cash has yet been paid. This matters in particular because participation by people with differences of vision or hearing cannot be left to unpaid 'goodwill'; it requires infrastructure for the labour involved. Only approved portions of the minutes are read at the open public meeting; the original private sound file is not played for everyone. The distinction between procedural explanation in a public investigation and a second violation of a private source is maintained.

Hamida's farewell song replaces the earlier circulating ridicule. Its 'road home' does not mean treating a daughter as an object to be expelled, but her right to return of her own choosing. The appearance on stage of an older woman's copper lota from the time of her marriage creates a new relation between personal memory and public art. The vessel, however, is not seized and converted into a symbol: it is returned to the woman. Sanket's automatic transcription device writes an incorrect word, which

Hamida herself corrects. This is a pleasing, concrete instance of the difference between mechanical copying and living linguistic authority. The moral meaning of the song, however, is often explained through direct statements, leaving somewhat less freedom for the reader to make meaning.

Chronology, Focalisation and the Decision That Results

Morning examination, midday public reading, an afternoon leaflet, the journey home in the evening and a notice board the following day establish a chronology in which the relatively slow pace of examination is set against the speed of rumour. The narrator moves the focal centre among Padma's expertise, Naira's self-doubt, Champa's memory of humiliation, Ruhani's wounded privacy, Hamida's professional judgement and Sanket's technical participation. The possibility of avoiding a novel devoted to the victory of one consciousness grows stronger here. Champa's particular observation—that an incorrect line may be crossed out, but an insult once heard does not leave the body in the same way—represents the continuing dimension of social memory in this work.

Separate entries are made for dues owed to Hamida and Chandra, but the cash is not paid in full. No fresh disclosure is made concerning Mahesh, and the expenses of Champa's treatment remain unsettled. A new order then appears on the notice board suspending payment under the contract, opening the causal question of the next chapter. The literary achievement is to teach the limits of validity through particular scenes without inventing a culprit. One weakness is that Padma, Ruhani, Champa and Hamida repeatedly speak in an astonishingly similar, clearly articulated ethical vocabulary. Greater differences in local idiom, hesitation, instability and the characters' incomplete self-explanations could have increased the complexity of dialogue. Nevertheless, the joint presentation of negative evidence from an amended sound recording and ownership of a worker's song gives this chapter its distinctive character.

Chapter 22 — The Order Concerning the Home

From the Notice Board to the Private Home: Three Distinct Spheres of an Order

The notice at the end of the preceding chapter becomes this chapter's opening scene. Payment on Naira's archival contract has been suspended and the delivery of new material stopped; the order does not specify any particular wrongdoing on her part. She asks the office clerk for two separate forms of evidence: a record of hours already worked and a receipt for materials submitted. The clerk provides no comprehensive

administrative remedy, but stamps one copy of her application as received. Naira does not automatically impose the conclusion 'retaliation' upon this event. After her breach of Mahesh's conditions, there is public controversy over her reliability, but the reason for the order has not been established. The scene therefore resists a straight line between punishment and revenge.

A notice orders Champa to vacate her rented room within three days. It carries a mark resembling a building-safety seal, yet does not clearly name the issuing official. The landlord cites a risk requiring repairs. Champa does not deny the actual dampness or cracks, but refuses to equate a building-safety inspection with a decision to remove a tenant without due procedure. Ruhani offers a bed in the temporary shelter; Champa keeps open the possibility of accepting help but retains the decision to leave the room. A broad structural echo can be identified here of the ancient Ayodhya Kanda's command to leave home and the obligation to obey; its modern form is explicit. This chapter, however, contains no independent scene set in Ayodhya. To call Rama and Sita's expulsion a direct plot-equivalent of Champa's eviction would exceed the evidence.

The third level concerns the encampment of Gauri Kapariya's itinerant group. An oral instruction to move has been given in the name of clearing the road, but not all the families in the group wish to stay at one location. Gauri records hours spent repairing tarpaulins and outstanding payments in her notebook, while refusing to make her individual route of travel and the children's private locations public. Her central objection—that to be mobile does not mean to be without a place—extends the conception of home beyond ownership of a fixed building. The common word linking the three levels is 'order', not an identical source of authority or consequence. This distinction is indispensable to a critical reading.

The Actual Register of Events: Staying a Decision Is Also an Event

The sequence of the plot consists of several simultaneous crises. The shelter's accounts bear new red markings against electricity, water, food and distribution of assistance. At a meeting Champa objects to the inclusion of her private medical documents in the shelter's collective accounts. Rukhsana demands a distinction between 'donated rice' and wages for cooking it. Gauri requires consultation among the itinerant families themselves. Ruhani re-examines her earlier inclination to sign on behalf of others and thereby take their decisions into her own hands. A working group is formed, but the roles of Champa, Rukhsana, Gauri and the shelter's older members are defined separately. Because her contract remains suspended, Naira does not claim authority to write an official report; she has the limit of her privately offered assistance with reading recorded in writing.

Kabir advises asking for a copy of the original order, arranging an inspection if there is immediate physical danger, and keeping disputes over occupation separate from questions of safety. He says a written objection is necessary, but does not present it as a guarantee that one may safely remain until nightfall. At the municipal office Champa learns that the notice was based on the building-owner's letter. No copy of a verified inspection is available at the counter. She obtains an acknowledgment recording 'inspection report not yet received'. The eviction order is not annulled at this moment; a question about its basis is merely placed on record. Gauri's group files a collective objection without revealing individual routes, while Rukhsana submits details seeking separate payment for cooking labour. All three acknowledgments are recorded in different registers.

After this, the notice is still on Champa's door; the crack remains in the wall, as do the shelter's bed and the lock. No permanent right of settlement has been established for Gauri's group. Rukhsana has not received payment; Naira's contract has not been restored. Nevertheless, narrative units 29–31 make the practical outcomes clear: Champa's possessions will not be removed automatically; the bed remains an option; the group will determine its own movements; and food-related dues will appear in a subsequent account. Protection of the right to decide has not somehow overtaken material resolution; both remain incomplete together. The chapter's closing question—'Who is above, which order governs, and whose right is it to decide?'—is the evidence-limited conclusion of all these events.

Objects, Labour and the Distribution of Caste and Social Voices

Champa's blue curtain and iron chest identify a private space. Gauri's tarpaulin is both bodily shelter and a resource for her mobile livelihood. Gauri stitches Champa's curtain for a modest fee. Through this transaction Champa is a customer, not simply a recipient of assistance; Gauri is a skilled worker, not an object of pity. The economical observation that stitching a tarpaulin differs from stitching a curtain conveys real technical knowledge of distinct kinds of labour. A girl in the group makes a small windmill from spare tarpaulin. The narrator does not immediately impose upon it a meaning as a proclamation of displacement. This is a rare instance of artistic restraint in the chapter: a brief game is allowed to exist without being forced to serve as a metaphor for crisis.

Rukhsana's words make the economic invisibility of domestic labour plain. She does not demand money from the people who receive her food; she raises the question when an institution enters the labour of cooking as zero in its accounts. The argument for labour rights is forceful in speech, but a limitation also emerges in a cautious reading: Rukhsana's economic question is settled at the immediate level of an acknowledgment stamp.

Additional scenes giving space to contradictory desires, fears or bargaining in her private life would have been useful. Gauri's insistence on stating the spelling of her name herself, her restricted consent to public information and her recognition of differing wishes within the group prevent her being reduced to the supposedly omniscient 'representative of a community' described by an outsider.

Focalisation, Temporal Recurrence and the Evidentiary Rules of Justice

The sequence moves from the office in the 'morning' to Champa's lane, the shelter meeting, midday advice, the municipal office before evening, the home at night and, elsewhere, the clerk's register. This creates the administrative intensity of one day. Beginning with Naira's admission of ignorance, the narrative spreads to Champa's personal decisions, Gauri's labour, Rukhsana's accounts and the external viewpoint of the office register. The clerk on the other side of the town is not an emblem of victory at the end; he files pages in separate sequences. Thus the narrator reduces the scope of claims to final decisions while increasing the plurality of recorded voices.

The narrative method is especially concerned here with drawing negative boundaries: a seal-like symbol without the official's name does not prove an actual inspection; a worker's oral statement is not a written copy of an order; acknowledgment of an application does not cancel eviction; the absence of a name from an itinerant-family list cannot establish that a person was not present; and materials obtained through donation do not prove that cooking was voluntary unpaid labour. These cases are not conceptually identical. Some concern criticism of sources, others rights, and still others causal inference. Rather than joining them all under the single formula 'evidence', an appropriate appreciation of the chapter's achievement must read them as different questions requiring different forms of proof.

Critical Appraisal: The Literary Cost of Incomplete Outcomes

'The Order Concerning the Home' constructs realistic social time by refusing a complete settlement. The need to remain safe for a single night in a damaged home and the long process of obtaining legal documents do not cancel each other out. Champa still holds the key to her room, but the three-day deadline may become the next chapter's actual crisis. At this point the critic can examine that possibility, not declare the matter concluded. Another weakness is that virtually every public conflict turns with extraordinary speed into a precise statement that 'these are two separate matters'. This clarity of ideas at times diminishes characters' private hesitations, contradictory social attachments and the uncertain

duration of bureaucratic resistance. Nevertheless, the repair transaction between Gauri and Champa, the little windmill scene free of didactic interpretation and Sarita's small question about a lock prevent the chapter from becoming merely a catalogue of documents.

Chapter 23 — Bharata's Refusal

The Lamp in Ayodhya: Legitimate Rule and Immediate Daily Needs

Leaving the preceding modern scene, the chapter enters the ancient temporal strand of the royal residence. A servant hesitates to order the trimming of an overlong lamp wick: between the death of a king and the resolution of succession, even a small routine act has become deprived of authority. Bharata lowers the wick himself. This opening scene contains the compressed narrative principle of the whole chapter. While the institutional seat remains undecided, smoke, fire, grain and fodder for animals cannot simply stand still. In the formal construction, the uncontrolled flame and uncertainty about political legitimacy illuminate one another, but one small competent act by a character does not resolve the crisis of sovereignty.

Bharata has received news of Dasharatha's death, but the message expressed in words and grief as lived experience are distinguished. Kaikeyi fails to fasten the clasp of a broken bangle. Bharata asks why a royal boon was sought in his name when he himself had never sought the kingdom. Kaikeyi's answer admits to fear concealed under the name of love; it does not amount to moral absolution. The question of an 'empty seat' brings forth opposition to depriving someone else of a right in the name of political gain. The unsuccessful attempt to fasten the bangle can symbolise the ethical fracture in the transfer of power, yet it is also a directly represented condition of a person, not merely a philosophical sign.

Positive Governance Within Refusal: A Causal Register of Events

In the assembly hall, a minister, a priest, the keeper of the granary and the officer in charge of the stables present different crises. Grain distribution has been interrupted for two days; the animals are running short of fodder. Bharata does not touch the royal insignia and declares that he will not have his elder brother's right to rule entered in his own name. At the same time he proposes opening the granary, maintaining the roads and ensuring that wages are not withheld. Refusal does not end with 'I will not'; it defines the precise sphere of provisional responsibility. His insistence that his own name be entered and that dissent over the disputed office also be recorded distinguishes the legitimacy of royal representation from the cause-and-effect work of administration.

Bharata requires that public services—food, care for the sick and security—be recorded separately from irreversible decisions or those involving conflicts of interest, such as grants of land, new declarations of succession and personal rewards. The minister expresses concern that the government will become weak. Instead of dismissing him, Bharata answers that making public trust in authority his personal property might simplify government but would destroy the moral significance of the original promise. This is a dialogue with genuine opposition. Nevertheless, the minister's case is given limited independent development, with the result that Bharata's ethical position appears almost unchallengeable from the beginning of the rewriting.

The evening meal moves the story from an administrative table into family conduct. Laughter about Shatrughna's childhood theft of ghee, Kausalya's question, Urmila's attention to the plates of the maidservants and discussion of who will attend to daily payments during Bharata's absence form a particularly human pause. Kaikeyi's silent presence is placed alongside everyday care. One shared meal at home does not grant judicial pardon, yet it gives people the capacity to get through the night. Urmila's question—'Who will decide the work of those who remain at home?'—rewrites the hero's departure for the forest from the perspective of labour left behind in the household.

From the Ancient to the Modern: Ruhani's Restricted Signature

From the ninth narrative unit onward, the same season appears in Videhapur. Rukhsana's stove, the shelter's windmill and the municipal maintenance letter form a modern counter-voice to the lamp in the royal residence. Ruhani receives a proposal to become the 'authorised contact person', together with a second document requiring details of a permanent transfer of the building. To secure maintenance and ration provisions, the secretary asks her to sign both at once. Ruhani places the two papers on separate tables: continuing everyday arrangements and becoming the owner of a house are not one decision. The actual operational correspondence between ancient Bharata's limited acceptance of office and modern Ruhani's limits on signature lies in this separation of documents; the characters do not share an identical psychological biography or stand in a relation of reincarnation.

Champa leaves open the possibility of choosing a bed at the shelter, but does not thereby agree to abandon her rented room. She leaves blank the register field that would reveal details of private medical treatment. Rukhsana enters donated rice, fuel and cooking labour separately. Kabir does not pronounce an assured legal verdict; he advises checking the original conditions governing the building and obtaining collective consent. Thus the reasoning behind Bharata's limited governance extends

into the fine distinctions of economic and residential decision-making. The royal episode in Ayodhya does not automatically apply to every modern administrative context. The analogy is meaningful only insofar as concentrated authority is separated, made conditional and rendered accountable.

Livelihoods in Motion: The Separate Narrative Arcs of Hasan, Zubaida and Hiravati

Hasan and Zubaida arrive near the shelter because their former place at the bus stand has been fenced off. Their old fee receipt proves use of that space on a particular day, not a permanent lease. Zubaida does not conceal this distinction. Her appeal seeks a definite daily time for setting up, a hearing, proper notice and an account of alternative sites. Hasan wants to use a wage slip he obtained from Amina at the ghat as proof of a permanent entitlement at the stand. Zubaida points out that it can help compare earnings from a new livelihood, but will not establish ownership of the bus-stand space. Through the characters' own dialogue, the narrative establishes the different domains in which different documents can serve as evidence.

Hiravati Kurariyar comes to repair a mat, but is expected to guard the premises without payment all day. She demands that the technical differences between these kinds of labour and their charges be recognised separately. Together the three stabilise a wobbly bench; the immediate task is completed, but the dispute over employment remains unresolved. This small practical demonstration does not abolish social complexity: it clarifies it. Hiravati retains authority over the spelling of her name, the date on which her work is completed and her entitlement to a copy of the record. Not having a phone does not reduce her right to receive a copy. A proposal is made to allow repairs for limited hours on the shelter's veranda, not to grant a permanent market space. Through these distinctions the occupational characters' story arcs move beyond a list: their work involves materials, hours, signatures and the risk to their earnings.

A Structure of Two Times, Narrative Voice and Philosophical Examination

The independent Ayodhya scene occupies the first eight narrative units; the modern strand runs from the ninth to the end. This does not merely mean 'an ancient story followed by a modern lesson'. The ancient scene's question about the labour of feeding opens the modern shelter's accounts of meals; grain held back at the granary connects with disputes over receipts for rations and repairs in the present. Yet the figures of the earlier age speak in an exceptionally modern idiom of consent, records and

distributive ethics. This may be an instrument of the declared rereading, not an authentic reproduction of historical dialogue. The cost of conceptual clarity is a reduction of the older age's distinctive modes of speech.

Four evidentiary distinctions are relevant: the designation 'contact person' is not permanent ownership; a fee receipt is not a permanent market lease; registration of a night spent in a shelter does not authorise complete disclosure of private medical treatment; and acknowledgment of a repair application is not acceptance of a complete transfer. In narrative terms these test the limits of the reasons adduced; the formal propositions, universal relations and entire logical method of a classical treatise are not quoted directly here. Changing the delimiter that qualifies an institutional title raises the question of the scope of the authorised decision. It is appropriate to call this a conceptual parallel for analysis, not to claim that the novel explicitly sets out a classical formula in its original wording.

The Final Outcome: Limited Consent, Incomplete Ownership

Ruhani submits a restricted maintenance request accompanied by an explicit statement of dissent. The office acknowledges receipt of that request; permanent transfer remains a separate question. Hasan has an old receipt and acknowledgment of his new appeal. The fee for Hiravati's repair work is being determined. Champa's room remains in dispute. At the end Naira records three bounded decisions in her notebook. The chapter rewrites Bharata's formal renunciation of kingship in terms of permission concerning a shelter, market fees and rights over private papers. Its achievement is to show that saying 'no' need not halt work, but can clarify the jurisdiction of responsibility. Its limitation is that the rapid reduction of nearly every complex situation to an apt legal formulation underrepresents the irregular obstacles of lived experience. Nevertheless, the final bucket and drops of water from the roof remind us that principle is not a substitute for actual repairs: put the bucket out today, fix the tap tomorrow. That material test of disciplined time opens the next chapter.

Chapter 24 — The Outer Veranda

A Crack in the Doorframe: From the Limits of Policy to Material Crisis

The chapter begins at dawn with a full bucket on Sarita's veranda and a new crack in its wooden doorframe. Sanket wants to make a support with his own hands, but Sarita will not take the risk without a carpenter's examination. Her maternal caution is not merely a rejection of a young person's skill; it places a value on the safety of hands and bodies. Since the

suspension of Naira's archival contract, the finances of home repairs have become disturbed. Sarita is prepared to contribute the savings from her sewing work, but remaining on the veranda until the rotten wood is replaced is dangerous. The stability of the kitchen in the first chapter now comes into conflict with structural instability in the house. Capacity is measured here not merely by keeping the stove alight, but also by a safe doorframe, a craftsperson's wages, a temporary room and the actual work of moving belongings.

In parallel, the three days allowed by Champa's notice have expired, and the landlord's agent has arrived at the door carrying a padlock. Seeing her mother's swollen knee and need for treatment, Champa decides not to spend the night in an unsafe dwelling, but preserves the inventory of belongings, acknowledgment for surrender of the key and dispute over the deposit. This departure is neither an uncontested acceptance of eviction nor a complete victory of rights. Champa places her own and her mother's papers in three distinct envelopes: rent receipts, treatment slips and private letters. The injury caused by the earlier leak of a personal message remains alive in this act of confidential organisation; the narrator does not reduce it to a piece of past information.

Three Families, Three Unequal Causes: An Extended Register of Events

The narrator explicitly identifies the structural centre of the chapter in narrative unit II: Champa moves temporarily because of a dispute over her room and her mother's health; Badri because rehabilitation is incomplete; and Sarita because of repairs and safety at home. These are not three 'examples' of a single political order. Badri's Nonphar family has received a slip assigning one corner of a new settlement, but drinking water, sanitation, travel and fare expenses remain unspecified. Badri has acknowledged receipt, not accepted permanent rehabilitation. His wife separately raises the children's medicines, tools, the goat's rope and transport charges among the things to be moved. The decision cannot be treated as the result of a lone man's signature.

Malati Koche already lives at the new settlement. She welcomes the arriving family while voicing concern about insufficient water. A shared tap, a muddy road and erosion during the night are risks that cannot be dispelled merely by writing 'alternative shelter' on a map. Malati does not want to lock the tap without her neighbourhood's agreement; neither does she wish to force the newcomers into a position of begging for water. She offers two glasses as personal hospitality and says plainly that this is not a permanent arrangement. Alongside the suffering of the displaced, the author makes the additional burden on an established community part of

the story. At this point the material administrative difference between 'settle everybody' and 'where will the water come from?' acquires literary credibility.

Sarita's family is moving into a small room near the railway square for two days; this is not the definitive abandonment of their home. The temporary support for the doorframe does not prove permanent safety. The carpenter's slip records the length of the crack, wet timber, the necessity of removing part of the roof and a date for reinspection. The question of tending the tulsi plant expresses emotional continuity with home. Sarita, however, forbids Sanket to enter the unsafe interior, and a neighbour offers a place to look after the pot outside. Through this small act, the narrative avoids the excess of sacrificing bodily safety simply to preserve the 'memory' of home.

The Original Sheet of Twenty-Seven Names: Bodies, Archives and Ownership

An exceptionally important ethical turn occurs in narrative units 17–19. The danger arising from replacing the roof raises the question of securing the original sheet of names held in Sarita's private chest. Naira offers an envelope, but Sarita decides to keep the original page in her own hands. Sanket does not photograph it; he only measures whether the cloth-wrapped bundle will fit in a small wooden box. Sarita ties the key into the loose end of her sari. The false death notice of Chapter 1 and the list of twenty-seven names of Chapter 2 now acquire a new condition of documentary ownership amid physical displacement: the house changes, but the keeper of the original evidence does not.

This scene also tests whether Naira has learned from her breach of Mahesh's conditional testimony. She does not demand authority over the original paper and agrees to record separately the status of other copies available for examination. Sarita reminds her of the old prohibition on reading out one particular name, and Naira says she will not violate it. The identity of that 'one name', or the mystery attached to it, is not disclosed in this chapter. What matters in the event is not revelation, but the conditions determining the right to disclose. The source-critical inquiry involved here must not be converted into a legal synonym for modern privacy: a document can serve as a means of testing truth, while the legitimacy of making it public remains a distinct ethical question.

Return Between Two Times: Bharata's Journey and the Labour Left on the Veranda

The Ayodhya scene of Chapter 23 returns in narrative units 23–24 of Chapter 24. Bharata prepares to go to Rama; Shatrughna asks about the

entries for grain and wages. The insistence that 'hunger will not wait for anybody's name' marks the continuity of everyday labour amid the suspension of decisions about political titles. Bharata accepts a woollen wrap given by Kaikeyi, but acceptance does not amount to complete forgiveness of an injustice. Urmila ensures that the dues for meals served to the women working in the household are entered separately. Thus the epic departure becomes not only the heroic traveller's journey but also a story of payments, food and care in the house left behind.

An interrelation can be discerned between the outer veranda of the ancient royal residence and the rain-soaked veranda of Sarita's home. In both places what matters more than departure is who will remain, how food will be prepared and who will guard the belongings. But the story does not make the two strands repetitions of a single historical event. Departure from Ayodhya is governed by questions of political and dynastic legitimacy, while temporary displacement in Videhapur follows from repairs, rent, care for the sick, water pipes and ownership of evidence. Maintaining these distinct causes is the first requirement of intertextual criticism.

Plate, Bowl and Lock: The Material Continuities of the Story

Sarita cooks rice in the newly rented room. Among the new container and new glass for water, the old brass bowl has come with her. The bowl carries not a house but a practice of measuring; the continuity of the 'account of the stomach' survives a change of physical location. The bed belonging to Champa's mother, Badri's pot left behind, Sarita's tulsi plant, the wooden box holding the name-sheet and Naira's three separate files are not one collective inventory of displacement. Each has a distinct value in relation to bodies, labour and memory. Champa lifts the flowerpot, Badri's wife avoids the danger of returning for a pot left in darkness, and Sarita touches the box's lock to check it. Through these acts characters change the social meanings of objects without changing their material identities.

By evening the three families occupy different positions: Champa's room has been locked and the deposit withheld; Badri has raised a temporary tarpaulin but has no permanent water supply; repairs to Sarita's house remain incomplete and residence near the railway square is temporary. Naira keeps the three crises in separate files and does not merge them with the private register of names. The last train whistle signals a new strand of travel. Incompleteness is not total defeat, but neither is it a happy ending. In this sense the chapter pushes the story's geography from the veranda towards the railway square and provides an event-based foundation for the next Vana Parva's opening concerns with movement and shelter.

Trauma, Focalisation and the Critical Counter-Argument

Concentrating the narrative on the intimate stability of one family would have intensified sentimentality, but the author creates a multifocal perspective through the differing needs of Champa's mother, Badri's wife, Malati, Rukhsana, the carpenter and Sanket. The work of separating decisions about safety from decisions about rights is continuous. A 'home' is constituted through papers of ownership, length of cohabitation, access to water, the possibility of making food and authority over one's own documents. Its particular social density comes from this material interdependence, not from a mechanically counted number of markers of change.

A weakness is that, as three serious crises—Champa's eviction, Badri's new settlement and Sarita's temporary departure—are handled within a single chapter, many characters speak in an unusually clear, restrained and procedurally correct idiom. Limited space is given to the psychological collapse eviction may bring, fear of discrimination in a new place, anxiety over illness from unsafe water, extended financial pressure from rent and conflicts within families. The author's restraint is a major virtue: material crisis is not converted into a display of pity. But excessive restraint also allows too little space for the disorderly human reactions generated by crisis. The chapter's final truth is severe enough: all three families are trying to secure safety, but this does not amount to proof of complete rehabilitation or victory in the struggle for housing rights.

Sabha Parva / Ayodhya Kanda: Comprehensive Parva-wise Narratological Assessment of Chapters 13–24

The Narrative Sequence of Twelve Chapters: From Humiliation to Departure from Home

The twelve chapters of the Sabha Parva are, in order, 'The Dead Woman Who Was Summoned', 'The Representative's Chair', 'Draupadi's Question', 'The Silence After Vikarna', 'Kaikeyi's Debt', 'Urmila's Night', 'Champa's Message', 'Premature Publication', 'Whose Voice?', 'The Order Concerning the Home', 'Bharata's Refusal' and 'The Outer Veranda'. Calling this sequence merely twelve successive ethical disputes would be inadequate. At the outset, Sarita's public declaration alongside the failure to correct her recorded death, the controversy over Ruhani's representative status, Draupadi's right to speak and the recording of Vikarna's dissent create a distribution of power within a public forum. In the middle sequence, Kaikeyi's promise, Urmila's night work, Champa's private message and Naira's haste increase the conflict between public decisions

and bodily risk. In the final four chapters, verification of audio recordings, orders concerning a contract and a home, Bharata's limited authority and the displacement of three families bring ethical statements into the tangible realms of home, food and dwelling. (Original Chapters 13–24.)

The structural outcome is this: a voice raised within the 'assembly' ultimately takes effect through a veranda, a room, a key, a rent receipt and a support for a roof. Justice is not simply a sentence declared in an assembly hall. Its outcome must also be measured by where a body can sleep at night, which worker receives payment and in whose hands a record remains. In this way the Sabha Parva forms a practical narrative bridge towards departure into the forest in the Ayodhya Kanda.

Who Has the Right to a Voice? Different Forms of Representation and Humiliation

The ancient thread of Draupadi's question and Vikarna's response creates a counterpoint to public humiliation; Champa's private message and Ruhani's representative position raise corresponding modern questions. Draupadi's royal assembly, however, is not interchangeable with Ruhani's committee or Champa's personal injury. To subsume them all under the abstract category of 'women's voices' would erase distinct causes involving payment for labour, public office, invasion of privacy, edited sound and housing. Chapter 21, especially, demonstrates through Hamida's remuneration for her singing and Padma's fee for facilitating communication that the right to speak means more than access to a microphone. It also requires payment for labour and infrastructure through which questions can receive answers. (Chapters 15–16, 19–22.)

Within this parva Naira is not only the heroine who reveals the truth. In Chapter 20 she carelessly publishes information made available subject to conditions. In Chapter 21 she must herself limit what she may publicly say. This adverse turn suggests that the novel's ethical order is capable of self-criticism. Yet most supporting characters express highly articulate legal and ethical judgements; their unequal experiences sometimes struggle against a tendency towards uniformity of speech. The claim to polyphony must therefore be tested not merely by counting participants, but through their autonomy of utterance and the long-term consequences of their divergent positions.

The Epic Relation to the Ayodhya Kanda: The Discipline of Differences Within Resemblance

The royal boon arising from Kaikeyi's fear, Urmila's obscured labour, Bharata's refusal to seize power and preparations for departure from the royal household provide definite points of contact with the modern

narrative. The author does more than establish similarities between ancient names. Bharata's ethical refusal is placed beside Ruhani's limited acceptance; wages owed to Urmila's maidservants beside payment for Rukhsana's cooking; and departure from Ayodhya beside the unequal displacements of Champa, Badri and Sarita. Yet the ancient characters speak in the terminology of modern regulatory principles. This is useful for conceptual reuse, but sometimes diminishes the verbal differences specific to an earlier age. It is an imaginative reconstruction of the ancient source, not an epic illumination that should be mistaken for direct quotation of the original words of the classical Ramayana.

Evidence, Permission and Consequence: Three Distinct Sequences

Throughout this parva written paper is repeatedly read at three different levels. First, evidence: what event or assertion has sufficient support? Second, permission: who has the legally and ethically legitimate authority to show or publish that evidence? Third, consequence: have receipt, inquiry and correspondence actually reduced someone's injury? An 'original audio recording' may constitute counter-evidence against a particular accusation without needing to be circulated publicly. An acknowledgment attached to Champa's notice is a real document, not the definitive annulment of eviction. Ruhani's permission for repairs does not transfer property. Naira's suspended contract provides only grounds for conjecture about an intention to retaliate. Concepts such as fallacious reasons, delimiters and qualifying conditions may serve as useful critical instruments for examining these relations, but literary analysis must not turn into the unsupported declaration that a classical formula has been directly applied in the text.

Density of Events and Recurring Chapter Endings: Achievement and Objection

The narrative's 'markers of change' per thousand words and the proportion of dialogue-bearing narrative units are automated measurements. The actual development of the plot in this parva is visible not in those figures but in its differentiated consequences: an accusation suspended, the leaker unidentified; a three-day notice questioned, the room vacated; acknowledgment of shelter repairs, ownership undecided; a contract stopped, a receipt for work demanded; one family on a shelter bed, one under tarpaulin, another in a temporary room at the railway square. These differences are actual transformations of events, not mere occurrences of particular signalling words.

Nevertheless, throughout the parva numerous chapter endings approach the formula 'a receipt has been obtained, but the right remains outstanding'. This recurrence of administrative obstruction remains close

to social reality, yet also threatens to render the rhythm of the story mechanical. Naira's mistake in Chapter 20, the reversal of meaning in the recording in Chapter 21, the humour of the repaired bench in Chapter 23 and the departure from home in Chapter 24 interrupt that sameness. This judgement is confined to the portion examined up to the end of the Sabha Parva, not to the complete text of eighteen parvas. How much causal weight these unresolved objects, documents and forms of homelessness acquire in the subsequent Vana Parva remains to be investigated.

Rasa, Resonance, Propriety and a Conclusion on the Critical Discourse

The pathos of humiliation, anger at the damaging of records, the restraint of Bharata's promise, Rukhsana's steadfastness in cooking labour and domestic calm in the rice prepared in a temporary home produce affect through particular situations. It would be inappropriate to pronounce them all the conclusive production of a single, determinate rasa. The lamp's wick, Hamida's copper lota, Champa's blue curtain, Gauri's tarpaulin, Hiravati's bench and Sarita's brass bowl carry possibilities of resonance, but the author sometimes immediately fixes their meaning in a character's direct declaration. The tension between the openness of figurative suggestion and the certainty of conceptual instruction constitutes a central strength and weakness of the parva's craft.

Conclusion on the parva. The narrative success of the Sabha Parva / Ayodhya Kanda lies in bringing public justice into the minute needs of the household. Forms in which authority is distributed—the chair, microphone, original file, fee, key, crack and plate—become narrative resources. Its weaknesses are the similarity of characters' ethical voices, the rapid juridical separation of some disputes and the repetition of acknowledgment slips. The last chapter ends not with a victorious return but with a conditional departure. It thereby establishes the tangible necessity of the Vana Parva that follows. A definitive overall assessment of the novel's entire 216 chapters cannot be pronounced on the strength of this single parva.

Vana Parva / Aranya Kanda

Chapter 25 — An Empty Space on the Train

Before the Train, the Sound of the Tap: The Real Beginning of the Action

The Vana Parva opens not with forest trees but with an empty bucket in a temporarily rented room. Sarita opens the tap: air escapes twice, and on the third attempt a thin stream of water appears. She asks Sanket to record the time. This opening follows directly from the displacement at the end of the Sabha Parva: accommodation has changed, but dependable water, food and domestic arrangements have not yet been secured. Naira's notebook still contains unfinished matters concerning three families from the previous day. Her desire to pursue an official complaint is not detached from managing water at home. The first event of the narrative is not simply that the tap runs; it is the beginning of a new measure of the time required to keep the cooking fire going.

Dawn at the station is Fakira's working time. Naira watches the clock for the office to open at nine; Fakira explains that missing the morning train means losing his first earnings. The unequal time of administration and labour is the central motivating conflict of the chapter. Naira offers to accompany him, but Fakira makes it clear that he will describe the route to the passengers himself: Naira cannot appropriate his right to represent himself. Assistance is not a licence to seize representation. The distinction also tests the lesson Naira has been developing since her earlier error in publication.

Four Economies at the Station: A Register of Facts and Decisions

The first subsidiary strand at the station concerns Sona Kathautiya's work transporting a bamboo framework. The handcart sticks in mud; Fakira identifies the safe edge of the drain by speaking; Sona supplies the physical strength. A charitable association wants to describe the transportation as 'social service' in its leaflet, although the cart-puller is owed two days' wages. Sona gives the cart-puller a copy of the tally of goods and insists on a receipt for his fare and the actual worker's consent before any photograph is taken. Ownership of labour, the attraction of visibility and the legitimacy of publicity collide in this small event. That the cart has moved does not prove that its charge has been paid. The association's representative gives no answer.

The second strand is Haricharan Paswan's small goods vehicle. Having transported a patient during the night, he must work again at dawn; the

driver's rest, petrol expenses and the journey-time ledger all raise questions of how working time is measured. Naira begins to ask whether trips to the warehouse might be connected with a crime, but remembers the earlier incident involving Mahesh and stops. In a sample receipt, Haricharan conceals the private customer's name while showing separate entries for vehicle hire and the driver's wages. It would have been an unauthorised inference to move from 'travelling near the warehouse' to 'participating in a crime involving its contents'; Naira does not publish that inference in this chapter. The empty stretcher at the rear of the vehicle recalls Urmila's work at the hospital, but this memory does not constitute fresh evidence of a crime.

The third strand concerns the withholding of Shiv Dhandhi's payment: the final letter of his name differs on two slips, preventing the signatures from being matched. Shiv produces his work ticket and demands that the number of days worked be preserved while the name is corrected. He does not consent to the inclusion of his name in Naira's private notebook; he takes home the receipt for an application submitted to the official. The fourth strand concerns a copy of an old labour contract belonging to Lakshmi Jhangar. She does not know who holds the original, and refuses to turn an old family payment claim and a household debt into one and the same demand. Shiv's receipt is not payment, and Lakshmi's copy does not authenticate an original. The chapter maintains these limits precisely.

Javed Kalandar's paper-puppet performance supplies a necessary counterpoint to this economy. He has abandoned performances involving live animals but needs a designated place in the public square, rent terms and working hours for his new livelihood. The station guard raises crowd-control concerns; Javed asks to see the measuring pegs. Fakira sings a folk tune for his own pleasure and refuses to have it entered on a payment slip. The writer distinguishes between 'all labour has value' and 'every creative act must instantly be recorded on a bill'. A voluntarily sung song does not automatically become a contract for unpaid work; nor may its singer be compelled to turn private enjoyment into an archival entry.

The Explosion of Rumour: The Limits of Direct Perception and the Consequences of a False Accusation

The decisive disruption at midday is a rumour that a child has been 'stolen'. In a crowd a woman is taking a child along; a young man wants to forward a photograph. Fakira asks whether anyone actually witnessed an abduction. At the information window, travel documents and a conversation establish that the child was travelling with a family member and that the problem concerned finding an elderly relative from whom they had become separated in the crowd. An official records the false rumour. One

particular accusation has been disproved by this inquiry; the narrative gives no ground for concluding that the cases of other missing children in the town have thereby also been settled.

Three levels of evidence remain distinct: the crowd saw a child in the woman's hand; the young man inferred an abduction; the inquiry established the family travel relationship. The first directly perceived scene is not a sufficient reason for establishing the second proposition of criminality. In the language of inference, one may examine the failure of the alleged reason to pervade the proposition to be proved, although the novel does not itself offer a formal five-member syllogism. Naira asks that the photograph not be circulated, but the young man is unwilling to delete the incomplete image. Thus, even after the inquiry has clarified the rumour, the risk of further digital circulation remains unresolved. Fakira's insistence that the entry concerning the child's safety be kept separate from his complaint about the closed service entrance is especially significant.

The Hour of the Hearing: Reorganising Administrative Time

Fakira counts again his morning coins, the price of tea and the afternoon train. He wants his complaint examined, but not at the price of sacrificing his earnings without compensation. Naira suppresses her immediate impulse to offer money and create a relationship of patronage. Instead, she chooses to understand the office's position and request a change in hearing time with the applicant's consent. The complaint remains active in the register, the check on the name is pending, and the entry incorrectly declaring him dead has not been corrected. The official suggests an afternoon appointment the following week; final confirmation depends on Fakira's signature. A 'proposed hearing' is not a 'hearing already held', still less a 'correction of the death entry'.

Fakira compares the proposed time with the uncertain schedule of the boat. The real time of a journey is more complex than the numbers on clocks and railway timetables: whether the boat runs in the rains, how long one must wait to cross, and how much daily pay is lost. Fakira decides to ask Hira himself; Naira renews her promise not to give a statement in his place. The boat narrative of Chapter 26 consequently begins without an arbitrary narrative leap.

Narrative Technique, Distribution of Knowledge and Critical Judgment

The third-person narrator moves towards Naira's private remorse and Sarita's anxieties about the home, but many people at the station define the limits of decisions in their own direct speech. Fakira is not wholly

ignorant because he 'cannot see': he understands social time through voices, footsteps, bags and the rhythm of vehicles. Yet he needs the application read aloud for examination, and the boat's time must be checked with Hira. Bodily knowledge is not turned into omniscience. At the spatial level, the railway square, platform, information window, drain beside the cart and tap in the rented house form a time-bound urban map. 'Empty space' means something different at each point: a dawn without earnings, a wage entry without its proper name, a rumour filled in against an innocent person, and the blank box Sanket creates for the afternoon train.

At the end Sanket draws a separate box for 'the afternoon train' in his notebook. In this pictorial conclusion the child learns not to squeeze administrative time, Fakira's earnings and his mother's cooking time into a single chronology. The title, 'An Empty Space on the Train', comes to signify not only an unoccupied seat in a carriage but also the available space for time and representation. The achievement is that the story makes consent-based cooperation visible instead of celebrating the heroism of charitable assistance. Its limitation is that, within a single morning, the many incidents involving Sona, Haricharan, Shiv, Lakshmi, Javed and the child-abduction rumour almost all find language of comparable ethical clarity appropriate to their resolution; clashes between discordant states of mind and the felt duration of actual procedural delay receive less space. Even so, the decision to leave Fakira's central grievance—the entry declaring him dead—unresolved reduces the danger of an easy didactic happy ending.

Chapter 26 — Guha’s Riverbank

Planks, Water and Crossing: How Physical Location Drives the Narrative

The slip proposing a hearing, obtained in Chapter 25, directly causes the beginning of this chapter. Fakira needs the boat's crossing time to assess whether the proposed midday hearing is practically attainable. Naira walks beside him, but on the rutted path Fakira retains the decision about where to place his feet; Naira merely points out hazards. Before a boat appears on the Tilwaha, the narrative shows wet planks, tightened iron joints and a rising waterline. The river is not simply a metaphor: it is a material constraint of weight, time, labour and physical safety.

Hira measures the boat's load and the waterline; Madhu Kevat consults the register of fares and journeys. Madhu explicitly states that crossing a river and crossing an international border are two different journeys. This one sentence prevents earlier episodes around Simatirtha from sliding into

imagined geography: a riverboat operator does not automatically exercise authority over papers at a border post. An unsigned slip behind the ghat calls free service by the boatmen's community an 'order'; Hira recalls that it was described as a proposal at the meeting. The publicity of a proposal as an order becomes an event requiring investigation in its own right; the writer does not identify the person who displayed the slip.

Guha's Ancient Timeline: Friendship and the Boatman's Independent Judgment

In its eighth passage the chapter returns to the ancient banks of the Ganges. Guha recognises Rama, Sita and Lakshmana, but after greeting them raises first the questions of the boat's wet planks, the community drying its nets and the safety of disembarkation. Against Lakshmana's impatience to travel, Guha insists on a safe route; Sita asks how help will be given to those who cannot swim. Guha establishes a rule of asking permission before taking someone's hand; Lakshmana accepts the condition that weapons be put aside. The princes' arrival does not bring the river workers' other daily tasks to an end.

Guha offers to meet the guests' boat fare from his own food resources, but does not promise that every future traveller will cross free of charge. There is a subtle difference between hospitality and professional labour. If hospitality depended on the boatman's unpaid work, friendship would become an unequal obligation. People preparing food, raising nets and rowing boats all continue their assigned work in the Ganges timeline. This ancient sequence furnishes an ethical counter-image to the modern slip demanding free service, but it would be wrong to call Guha a literal modern counterpart of Madhu or Hira. Nor should this invented dialogue be treated as a verbatim historical quotation from the classical Ramayana.

Boat Capacity and Unverified "Relief Supplies": Cause and Effect

In the modern timeline, closed sacks from a private shop demand free space aboard the boat by bearing the label 'relief supplies'. Madhu questions the matching of names; Hira makes it clear that removing two sacks would create safe room for two passengers within the load limit. A heading on a document is insufficient proof of the contents, and generous policy language does not enlarge a boat's capacity. The shopkeeper scolds a labourer, and Madhu insists that the dispute should be taken up with the owner himself. The causal sequence in this small scene is concrete: incorrect classification, a conflict of loads, misplaced blame on a worker, and a demand to correct the classification. Yet the work gives no judicial finding that the sacks have officially been proved fraudulent.

Lakhan Satar's ledger for a night-time contract to repair planks has been converted into 'community service'. Lakhan records separately the hours worked by two companions, seeking shares for all three rather than a receipt for himself alone. Nandu Nat and Hari Natuwa, members of separate theatrical groups, measure the place for a performance stage, but insist on protecting children's school hours. They resist an attempt to extend the administration's logic of a 'free boat' into a demand for a 'free show'. This recurrence is not merely repetition of an idea. It criticises the confinement of three different economic arrangements—boat work, manual repair and cultural labour—within the single public category of 'service'.

Rita Ekka finds her name attached to another person's debt entry. She will not sign without the original agreement; rather than copying Rita's private particulars, Naira records the public fact that there is no procedure for applying to match names in the debt register. Ramani Bind does not treat her fishing lease for Barki Pokhari as proof of rights over every river ghat; Renu asks for distinct times for access and washing clothes at the ghat. These three claims—debt, fishing rights and ordinary passage—concern separate jurisdictions, not necessary subsidiary scenes of a single claim. The rules governing the boat's load capacity remain separate as well.

Two Names for the River and the Prohibition on Geographical Guesswork

An old letter from Renu's maternal home writes 'Bagmati', while another copy reads 'Bangmatti'. Renu herself explains that the letter concerns an earlier use of water, not a measurement of the Tilwaha's actual course. Naira does not draw a new confluence on the map. Here the text maintains an evidentiary difference between historical readings of river names and the actual network of waterways. In narratological terms, the directly attested variant reading provides no reason to infer a geographical confluence; similarity of names is not a universal concomitance. The intellectual achievement lies in this restraint, although the explicit caution about river names momentarily interrupts the natural current of the story and sounds rather like an academic annotation.

The First Crossing: An Event Accomplished, a Policy Undecided

After the planks are tightened, Hira checks where weight can be placed in an empty boat; Madhu tests the rope; the first crossing begins under a limit of four passengers and two small bundles. Fakira boards at his own pace; Naira does not cross unnecessarily. 'The boat moved' is a concrete, verified narrative success. But a safety check performed today does not certify safety at tomorrow's water level; Hira records the time of the next check. Madhu proposes that the cost of helping an emergency patient be met from an

assistance fund: this is a proposal, not an order. The boatmen's wages have not automatically been waived in the name of government aid.

Rita obtains acknowledgement of her request for the original debt agreement, not a settlement; Lakhan's group receives separate receipts for daily wages, not full payment; and the complete stage contract for Nandu and Hari remains outstanding. Amid these unfinished matters, Sanket for the first time adds a place for the boatman to sit in his drawing. The child's picture attempts to complete the abstract plurality of 'all the passengers' by including the labour that moves the boat. At the concluding meal, Sarita, Naira and Sanket understand that crossing safely is the combined outcome of numerous conditions, not the beneficence of one hero.

The Purpose of Two-Timeline Narration and Its Critical Counterpoint

The narration cuts twice between Guha's Ganges and the Tilwaha at Videhapur. The ancient timeline has Guha's friendship, the boatmen's meals and the routes of fishing nets; the modern one has Madhu's ledger, Hira's measurements, Lakhan's wages and Fakira's journey. The object linking them is the boat, but their social rules are not identical. The story unsettles the inherited atmosphere of devotional reverence by asking about the worker's right to decide. Guha possesses practical operational knowledge even within the ancient story. On the level of rasa, the affection of hospitality and friendship accompanies an apprehension of accident; ethical suggestion arises from the conditions of safe cooperation.

One limitation is that ancient characters speak very explicitly in the modern vocabulary of consent and remuneration, potentially diminishing the complexity of contradictions within the epic age. In the contemporary sequence, too, several applications, receipts and regulatory classifications progress coherently within a single day, compressing the long experience of institutional obstruction. Yet the author does not offer solutions at an impossible speed: the slip is reclassified from 'order' to 'proposal'; the boat completes one crossing; the debt and the wages remain unresolved. It is therefore fairer to regard the chapter not as administrative publicity but as a narrative about the value of labour and the limits of knowledge.

Chapter 27 — Shabari’s Dawn

The Labour of Food Within the Time of Waiting: Reconstructing the Opening

The chapter opens at a hearth in ancient Dandakaranya. Shabari sets aside wet firewood and wood that is dry within; people of the hermitage fetch water, stitch leaves and prepare an ointment for a sick person. The guest has not yet arrived, but the work is already under way. Rather than

beginning from the arrival of the guest, as the conventional Shabari narrative tends to do, this opening rests on the labour that precedes the provision of food. The memory of Matanga remains revered, but dry fuel is required to light the hearth. The tension between the cultural significance of remembrance and the physical requirements of the body becomes the chapter's principal suggestion.

The narrative does not confine Shabari's waiting to passive devotion. Karuna's mother is injured, and Karuna wants to take ointment to her promptly. Shabari does not pressure her to abandon her obligations at home on account of the awaited visitor. She recalls an earlier injustice in the distribution of fruit: the best fruit was reserved for visitors, while working women received what had fallen. She questioned this practice. Nothing changed immediately, but the order of distribution changed over time. This memory is a direct analepsis: the reasons for the current decision about food lie in an earlier dispute. Shabari's ethics of labour does not descend as sudden, omniscient truth; it results from dissent sustained over time and a partial reform.

When word comes that Rama and Lakshmana are approaching, Shabari does not rush off with a basket of fruit. First comes the medicine for Karuna's mother, then the hermitage's regular meal, and only afterwards the guests' serving. This order does not diminish the epic visitors; it redistributes priorities. Mriga says that she picks the fruit, yet other people's names appear when the story is told; Shabari encourages her to speak for herself. Here the visibility of labour is linked to the right to narrate: the person who does the work ought also to be able to speak of the experience.

Dialogue with the Visitors: Food, Routes and Independent Testimony

When Rama and Lakshmana arrive, Shabari explains the way to the water source but also reports that the old short path is blocked by a tree fallen during the rains. Her answer to a guest's question rests on knowledge tested at a particular site; the forest is not represented merely as a place of spiritual seclusion. Shabari sets aside fruit reserved for the sick before offering food: not everything 'available' is food that the guest is entitled to take. Rama's gaze turns from the fruit vessel towards the working hands behind it. Mriga gives her own name and explains the risks of the marshy shortcut. Her name is not merely appended to the labour register; she becomes a source of decisive knowledge about the route.

Shabari tells Rama explicitly that the hearth will burn after the visitors have left, and the workers who provide service will need rest. Karuna leaves to visit her mother; no theory of narrative duty is invoked to hold her back. Shabari herself decides to release Mriga from work at the evening

hearth. In these ancient scenes, the story moves beyond moral praise for 'service' and opens political questions about the allocation of service, unequal expectations, health and rest. Yet this dialogue is not verbatim historical text from the original Ramayana: it is the voice of an invented epic timeline within the novel. Criticism identifies the purpose of its modern reinterpretation rather than passing it off as textual evidence from the ancient work.

The Modern Community Kitchen: Two Distinct Meanings of "Free"

In the thirteenth passage the narration arrives at the community kitchen beside the railway square in Videhapur. Sarita comes to inspect the grain accounts; rice, lentils, hot water and supplies for medical dressings are laid out on a shared veranda. The separate use of clean cloth sent by Urmila recalls the practical requirement to keep cloth for patients apart from cloth used in cooking. Urmila's outstanding wages have not yet been received, but her knowledge of work affects institutional practice even in her absence. Narration shows the consequences of a character's actions without requiring her bodily presence; absence is more than the recollection of a name.

A board reads, 'Community Meals: Service Free of Charge'. This statement opens two fields of meaning: a right to free food for its recipients, and unpaid labour for those who cook, transport and repair planks. Flour, salt and wood are tied separately on Mira Banjara's cart. Five sacks are visible where the slip records seven; immediately, an accusation arises that two have 'disappeared'. Sarita says that the hungry elderly woman should be given bread first. Narrative action here does not suspend the work of keeping people alive until a numerical dispute has been settled.

Kedar Bauri's wages for repairing the veranda have been withheld under the name of 'service'. Beside Ramu's rain-soaked time slip, the manager's form contains a box marked 'volunteer', not 'labourer'. Seeing Poonam Chirimar's surname, the manager tries to confine her to an ancestral occupation of catching birds; in fact, she now stitches mesh coverings to protect grain and sends her child to school. In these episodes, caste or community surnames, present occupations, contracts for labour and inherited stereotypes are separate questions of evidence. The novel does not demand the erasure of community identity; it resists the reasoning that a traditional occupational story automatically proves someone's present livelihood.

As Poonam's daughter learns to write the word 'free', she asks about its meaning. The answer teaches her that the price to the recipient may be zero, but the producer's effort is not zero. In this small classroom, learning letters and learning meanings become one. This is a subtle achievement of

the chapter's verbal craft: an ethical implication emerges from the child's question about a word rather than only from the narrator's lecture. Nevertheless, the women's replies are composed like exceptionally precise statements of principle, potentially limiting the ordinary uncertainty of social conflict.

Seven Sacks: Original Count, Distribution Across Sites and Correction of Error

Shanti Bote steps off the boat and explains that two sacks were at a distribution point on the opposite bank and five in Videhapur's kitchen. The initial list had assumed that all seven arrived at one place at once. Mira accepts responsibility for goods delivered by her cart; Shanti uses the unloading-fare slip for her boat to distinguish the actual locations of the supplies. Naira asks that goods entries be checked without unrelated private passenger names. Once the available entries are reconciled, the theft rumour proves false, and the manager posts a correction on the public board: 'Error in Counting'. Rather than merely dropping an unsubstantiated accusation with the words 'Mira is innocent', this correction sets out the objective basis of the inquiry.

The narratological analogy must be understood carefully. The initial assumption of seven sacks at one location depended on a wrongly specified subject. A direct count of five sacks does not establish that two were stolen, because distribution took place at two sites. A change of location does not change the sum of the quantities. Examining the copies, receipts and boat slips together exposes the qualification overlooked in the mistaken inference. Yet this successful inquiry does not settle the kitchen's financial questions: Kedar is still owed four days' arrears and payment for today's hours. Opening a new accounting category for his wages constitutes only an initial acknowledgment. The writer makes the correction of a false charge and justice for workers separate outcomes.

Half a Plate, a Whole Right: The Sovereignty of the Body

On arriving at the hearth, Fakira insists on moving along his route independently and choosing his own quantity of food. Sarita stops the manager's proposal to put a red mark after the name of anyone taking only half a plate, so that they will not receive a full quantity of grain next time. Accounting for consumption may be necessary, but reducing a person's future entitlement on the basis of the amount taken at one meal is an unwarranted inference. Final authority over Fakira's body, hunger and preferences rests with him. The difference between the arithmetic of distribution and human dignity produces an ethical suggestion. It is not a narrative quotation of a formal Nyaya aphorism, but an analysis emerging from the characters' exchange.

No definite answer is available about whether the kitchen will function every day. A proposal for annual community accounting emerges, but Kedar objects to postponing his daily arrears until an annual event. Discussion of the old route for collecting wood having been closed, regulations for forest protection and the need to keep the hearth burning despite these rules provides the clear causal link to the next chapter. Mira does not immediately crush her younger sister's desire to take a separate route to market; she says they will examine the expenses for two days before deciding. There is no agreement yet, but no humiliating refusal either. At the end Shabari and Mriga share the remaining fruit. The two hearths in different times are not equivalent: the Dandakaranya hermitage states that no one will sleep hungry that night, whereas the community kitchen's permanent future in Videhapur remains uncertain. Treating this difference as a single final happy ending would contradict the text.

Narrative Levels, Rasa and Structural Objections

The ancient timeline extends through the opening twelve passages; after twenty-two passages of the modern narrative, the final scene returns to Shabari. This is not a one-way journey 'from ancient to modern' but a two-layered narration accomplished through the recurrence of objects. Drying wood, rice, fruit, plates, food reserved for the sick, Mriga's name and Poonam's occupation all return with different claims in different times. The possibility of karuna rasa lies in hunger, arrears and deprived labour; a modest element of humour appears in the child's question and Fakira's remark about half a helping of rice. The primary suggestion here is the coexistence of free distribution and labour accorded dignity.

An important achievement is that the narrator does not transform 'Shabari's service' into one grand emblem of devotion and make every other worker invisible. Instead, Karuna's and Mriga's particular interventions are preserved. In the modern part, the contributions of Mira, Shanti, Kedar, Poonam, Urmila and Fakira create a dialogic counterpart. There are two limitations: ancient speakers use the disciplined language of present-day rights discourse excessively; and the dramatic allegation about the kitchen's count, its investigation and its public correction are completed comparatively quickly. The long-lasting social harm caused by a rumour consequently receives less experiential space. Nevertheless, the unfinished questions of Kedar's payment and continuity of food distribution prevent the chapter from becoming merely a didactic example.

Chapter 28 — Hidimba's Pact

Life After Violence: The Opening at an Ancient Forest Encampment

The chapter opens at a stopping place on the Pandavas' forest journey, far from Dandakaranya. Hidimba gathers broken bamboo; marks from the quarrel of the day before remain on the bark; Hidimb is dead. Yet Hidimba's life does not thereby shrink to the sole purpose of 'Bhima's love'. The children's paths for gathering tubers, the trail of a pregnant doe and the safe footing on wet soil are continuing responsibilities of the forest. Bhima lifts the bamboo; Hidimba directs him where to put it. The distinction between physical strength and local environmental knowledge emerges from their dialogue. Bhima's strength does not cancel Hidimba's authority.

Hidimba neither forgets her brother nor accepts his violent commands. This is not a simple opposition between grief and love: a person can remember a relative's death while continuing to resist his wrongdoing. Bhima asks, 'Will you come with me?' Hidimba changes the premise of the relationship: what kind of relationship can be possible, and with whom, while she stays in her forest? Before Kunti she sets out her conditions: no obligation to leave the forest, a mother's voice in the child's upbringing and name, and no thrusting the child into ancestral military duty from birth. The marriage question is thus transformed from 'Where will the heroine go with the hero?' into an agreement concerning place, children, time and autonomy.

Bhima acknowledges that he cannot abandon his brothers' journey. Hidimba values promises that can actually be kept. An elderly woman of Hidimba's community listens and makes three signs of remembrance on the bark: agreement to remain, honesty about departure and the child's own future. This is not a formal royal document in the classical sense, but memorial testimony placed before the community. Hidimba states clearly that the blood of a child is not a tax levied by birth; should a crisis arise in the future, the child must have an independent say. A possible intertextual foreshadowing of Ghatotkacha's future sacrifice in the Mahabharata can be recognised in this statement. The chapter, however, gives no grounds for claiming that Ghatotkacha has been born, that the later war has occurred or that he has died in these events.

The Rains of 2039: A New Gate, an Erased Official Designation and the Crisis of Access

The ninth passage explicitly announces the modern time: 'Videhapur, the rains of 2039'. The reply to the previous chapter's debate about closing the path for firewood comes in the form of a notice posted on the gate in the

morning: the route along the forest edge is closed. The date is legible, but rain splashes have erased the designation of the issuing official. Ramu stands with an empty cart; Mira's younger sister has an empty basket in her bag. The scene shows how a notice restricting access can prevent an opportunity for daily work before that opportunity has even begun. But the designation is effaced, so the source of the prohibition is not itself certain.

Batohi Dhami, carrying a honey vessel, wants to inspect a hive, not immediately cut it down. The guard possesses a two-day duty slip, not authority to issue the principal prohibition. Devaki Pal needs a safe seasonal grazing route for her goats; the rear drain is full of rainwater. Devaki's document contains the name 'Khairi', but she herself does not know whether it has any geographical connection to the Tilwaha. Tara limits the use of the document to understanding an older practice of access, rather than inventing a new name for the present river. A historical copy about an animal route and the current physical danger of a drain do not constitute one and the same kind of evidence.

Closing the route will force Tulsi Tajpuriya's goods vehicle into the town's school lane; the regular route for Rozi Lalbegi's waste-sorting work has been blocked. A young man completing a temporary register guesses Rozi's religion and occupation from her surname and enters both in one box. Rozi disputes this: present work, religious identity and surname are not the same thing. He strikes out the inference and records the information separately. This small administrative act of social classification shows the danger of effacing identity without requiring a violent slur in the story. Mangari Gorait has a separate claim for wages owed by a closed factory. The guard does not possess its payroll register, so Mangari does not pronounce him guilty of the factory owner's wrongdoing.

Separating the Demands: The Actual Procedure for a Joint Application

Naira requests permission before looking at Batohi's map. Batohi makes secrecy about the hive's exact location a condition, for the protection of both the bees and the crowd. Gomati does not establish the cause without measuring the drain's gradient; Tara marks the gate, drain and footpath separately. No order is attached to Aditi's name through speculation. Three fields of evidence remain distinct: 'someone saw', 'someone read in a copy', and 'which official issued the order'. Privacy is no longer only a matter concerning people; it also concerns the protection of a vulnerable ecological entity—the beehive.

Someone in the crowd suggests breaking the lock. Batohi and Mangari disagree: breaking it will establish neither forest rights nor the payment of

wage arrears. Rather than dissolve the different matters into one application, Mira creates separate entries—for honey, the grazing route, transport, regular waste work, factory arrears and Kedar's unpaid repair work. Mangari acknowledges that an old identity card is not an entry pass. The guard's contract mentions the protection of a warehouse but does not show an independent order authorising the closure of a public footpath. That absence does not establish that access is entirely unrestricted by law; it merely weakens the basis for the claim of a 'final prohibition by the Forest Department'.

Tulsi chooses an alternative route to deliver the grain on time and enters the increased transport charge separately. Rahina Thakurai confirms her ability to transcribe letters from an old wage register but will not identify the office to which an incomplete seal belongs without the original. Mangari resolves to account separately for each worker's days. After midday a staff member explains that the legal status of warehouse security and the common footpath will be examined separately. For now entry is restricted to the survey team conducting measurements; general passage remains barred. The request to provide copies of the relevant papers within three days is acknowledged, not promised an answer. The gate does not open as an immediate consequence of this procedure.

Three Marks on Bark and Four Applications: The Limits of Intertextual Composition

The ancient narrative condenses agreement about the Hidimba–Bhima relationship, residence in the forest and the rights of future children into three marks. The modern narrative creates different recipients of rights through Mira's four copies: the office, people using the route, wage claimants and those unable to attend the hearing. This is not grounds for hunting a numerical correspondence. The three ancient marks and four modern copies perform different social functions. Their resemblance lies in the questions 'To whom does a promise apply?' and 'How are the rights of an absent person protected?' Hidimba's child retains the right to consent about its future; the modern application's copy preserves the participation of an absent worker. Yet the two cannot be treated as the same institutional process or as evidence of historical continuity.

The ancient forest camp returns amid the modern scenes. Bhima accepts the condition that Hidimba may speak if she changes her mind; Hidimba refuses to regard silence as a permanent promise. Remembering her brother while refusing his violent orders, keeping forest paths communal and determining the limits of her own home all pose ethical counter-questions to the dispute over the modern gate. But the modern gate requires registers, contracts, legal status and official receipts. Ancient

personal agreement does not automatically replace them. In that difference lies the real intellectual potential of the novel's experiment with two timelines.

The Final Position: The Gate Closed, Relations Still Open

By evening Devaki has not led her goats into the deep drain; Batohi has not been able to inspect the hive; Rozi has no permanent permission to follow her working route; Mangari's arrears remain due; and Kedar's wages have not been paid. Tulsi has delivered the grain, but the increased cost of transport is still at issue. Naira tells Sarita that the path is not yet open; what has been obtained is a procedure for requesting a copy of the original order. The final scene shows Devaki's small goat chewing a rope and someone speaking of assembling again tomorrow. Here a 'pact' is not a collective signature on a settlement document. It is the story of conditional, provisional cooperation among people with differing aims.

One limitation is the excessively modern language of agreement used in the initial ancient exchanges with Hidimba. Her dialogue explicitly articulates contemporary ideas of freedom, accountability and children's rights. This fulfils the aim of a post-epic reinterpretation but reduces the historical distance of the characters' speech. At the modern gate, numerous social groups appear in sequence and explain the correct classification of their identities. Although this expands representation, it sometimes resembles an orderly display of an occupational list. Yet, countering that list-like form, the characters' specific costs—the honey hive, animals' safety near water, transport risk in the school lane and the unverified seal —enter the story as real obstacles. Most important, the author does not invent an unverified triumph in which the gate opens. The chapter ends among a definite acknowledgment, an unfinished investigation of the order and the insecurity of labour on the following morning.

Vana Parva / Aranya Kanda: Comparative Discussion of Chapters 25–28

From the Sabha Parva to the Vana Parva: The Economy After Displacement

At the end of Chapter 24, Champa, Badri and Sarita suffer different forms of temporary displacement. Chapter 25 opens with water in Sarita's rented room; Chapter 26 seeks the boat's crossing time to assess the practical possibility of Fakira's proposed hearing; Chapter 27 moves from the earlier crossing to the dispute over distribution at the community kitchen; and Chapter 28 moves from discussion of the route for the kitchen's firewood to the crisis caused by the forest gate. In this sequence, the primary cause of

each new chapter lies in an unfinished state from the preceding one. The train, boat, kitchen and forest path do not merely mark 'changes of place': they form a causal chain of livelihood, food, safety and rights. (Original Chapters 24–28.)

Temporal Construction, Focalisation and Three Different Forms of Intertextuality

Chapter 25 centres on a layered single day in the modern railway square: the train at dawn, the office at nine, the proposed hearing at midday and the cooking fire in the evening. Chapter 26 alternates between the modern Tilwaha and Guha's ancient Ganges. Chapter 27 has a semicircular construction, from Shabari's dawn in antiquity through the modern kitchen and back to an ancient evening. Chapter 28 moves from Hidimba's ancient dispute over a relationship to the gate at 'Videhapur, the rains of 2039', then returns to ancient dialogue. Thus, 'the Vana Parva employs two timelines' may be broadly true, but the temporal arrangements of the four chapters are not the same. (Chapters 25–28, corresponding openings and conclusions.)

Focalisation is likewise not fixed upon one person. Naira is the principal recurring observer, but Fakira determines the time of his earnings, Madhu the boat fare, Guha the safety of the riverbank, Shabari the distribution at the hearth, Mira the locations of goods, Hidimba the forest's local knowledge and Rozi the classification of her social identity. The importance of this multicentred perspective does not automatically prove the full verbal autonomy of each character: several speak in the same rhythm of ethical clarity. A plurality of characters is therefore not identical with a plurality of voices. The novel's achievement is to show numerous locations of social knowledge; its possible limitation is the comparatively narrow range of real linguistic disagreement among distinct speakers.

Three Movements of Evidence and the Ethics of Social Labour

Evidence has different statuses across the four chapters. In Chapter 25 Fakira's complaint remains active and there is a proposal to change the hearing time, not a correction. In Chapter 26 the boat has moved, but the legitimacy of the slip's order for free service has not been established. In Chapter 27 the error in counting seven sacks has been corrected, but Kedar's wages have not been paid. In Chapter 28 a receipt for a request to examine the gate order's original source has been obtained; general access is still closed. The distinction among these four narrative outcomes is the test for reading: application, proposal, inquiry, practical trial, public correction and final justice are separate stages.

From the perspective of Indian poetics, the recurrence of wet planks, an empty bucket, drying wood, the knot at the gate and an unoccupied place for the boatman produces symbolic suggestion, or vyanjana. Hunger and humiliation provide the occasions for karuna, but the characters' small moments of humour prevent suffering from accumulating in a single unbroken mood. The question of propriety, aucitya, is bound principally to the material reasons for decisions—the boat's load limit, the fare at the ghat, the quantity of food and the risk of travelling through the forest. In the discussion of evidence, the distinctions among perception, verbal testimony, inference and absence furnish appropriate analytical tools. It would be improper to present these fictional situations as actual passages from original classical aphorisms formulated in the narrative.

Provisional Critical Judgment and Questions for Further Inquiry

The chief achievement of the first four chapters of the Vana Parva is that they do not treat epic exile merely as an emotional synonym for modern displacement. They make it a complex narrative of working time, local knowledge, women's labour, the value of work, autonomous decisions within particular communities and ecological responsibility. Yet in most episodes the narration provides ethically alert characters with appropriately articulated solutions; it grants comparatively little depth to irregular confrontations, prolonged administrative inaction, the private trauma of humiliation and complex social divisions. This is only a provisional conclusion about Chapters 25–28, not a final verdict upon the entire Vana Parva (Chapters 25–36). The next sequence, Chapter 29, 'Child Thief', will have to re-examine the consequences of the child-abduction rumour and the crowd's claims to evidence. No event or resolution from that chapter is declared here without first examining the original Chapter 29.

Chapter 29 — Child Thief

Yesterday Evening on This Morning's Screen: The Temporal Deception of the Opening

The chapter begins with images of the rain-soaked forest gate spreading across mobile phones in the railway square. The video contains a few moments showing Janaki's back, a child's hand, the bamboo gate and someone shouting 'Catch them!' Then comes an accusatory caption: 'Child Thief Caught This Morning.' The first problem is not whether the images themselves are false, but the discrepancy between the visual scene and the caption's temporal context. Fakira's question—'Who recorded this in the morning?'—immediately distinguishes presentation from the actual time of the event. The young man's reply, 'It was forwarded today', does not establish when it was filmed. From the outset the reader can perceive the

gap in visual evidence, but the group has already forwarded the video. The opening turns the speed of a rumour's narration into a social event: the time taken to transmit a copy between two phones is shorter than the time required for an actual investigation.

Janaki's bodily reaction is an immediate consequence of this public defamation. She is drying her troupe's wet sheet when an unfamiliar mother sees her and pulls her daughter's hand away. A partial picture showing Janaki from behind is already altering how people behave towards her face to face. The elderly Saryu asks, 'Will you put a lock on my mouth as well?' This creates a tension between presence and absence: the community has been deprived of the right to see the complete scene, while being required to remain silent. Compared with the forest of the ancient epic, this modern 'forest' is not merely uncontrolled nature; it is a site of social exclusion produced through digital circulation.

Register of Events: Not Two Accusations but Two Different Sequences of Problems

The first sequence is the investigation into the viral charge against Janaki's troupe. Naira asks her for details, but Janaki sets a prior condition: the child's face must not be made public again. Naira's earlier mistake of publishing Mahesh's testimony before the agreed time now becomes a memory that governs action. She puts away her phone and takes out her notebook, promising not to give names without permission. Janaki authorises the recording of only three points: she was present near the gate; one child was with the child's mother; and no abduction occurred before her eyes. She acknowledges that she heard incompletely whom the crowd meant by 'Catch them!' In this admission a witness's recognition of the limits of knowledge becomes a source of strength for the inquiry, not a claim to omniscience.

The second entry concerns the attendance register of Mira Mandal, a temporary schoolteacher. Parents' fear accounts for the absence of three children from class. Mira makes clear that the register establishes an interruption of schooling, not the identity of an abductor. The fact that a child was in class yesterday does not identify the child in the video; the time covered by an attendance entry is not a record of a person's movements for an entire day. Naira does not photograph a list of every child at the school. She asks only for a written basis for the relevant times. This is not a careless reluctance to gather information, but a method of selecting pertinent evidence while protecting children's identities.

A third piece of evidence is Durga Danuwar's receipt for transporting bamboo. The crowd wants to dismiss her bamboo route as secondary to 'the child matter'. Durga supplies the date and the number of bundles, but

expressly acknowledges that she did not witness the whole scene. The guard at the gate also says he detained no child. His wet duty slip establishes the time at which vehicles were prohibited from entering, but he does not consider himself authorised to provide an unofficial named copy. Durga's labour ledger and the guard's slip define the temporal and spatial limits of the incident; they do not offer a complete account of a crime.

The fourth inquiry reaches the original recording. The phone through which the video was circulated showed the time the file was 'received', not when it was created. A friend of the young man who made the original recording comes forward, but because revealing the child's face poses a risk, Janaki stipulates a controlled viewing with no copies distributed. Naira does not pretend to be a technical expert. She records the file date, the order of images and claims of ownership in separate entries. In the original footage, the notice at the gate, Tulsi's grain vehicle and Durga's bamboo transport can be correlated with the time in the food register obtained from Mira. It is established that the previous evening was labelled 'this morning'—a distortion of context. Who added the false caption remains unproved.

During this inquiry a new, independent event occurs. Lata reports that her eight-year-old son Mithun has gone missing from the market. The case is no longer 'a viral allegation of child theft' but 'a report of an actual missing child'. Mithun's blue kurta, a scarf that bleeds red dye, a broken sandal strap, three minutes spent outside an oil shop while his uncle was occupied, a possible northern lane and the possibility of the railway: these are separate, uncertain leads drawn from different accounts. The crowd grows suspicious of Sabina Mirshikar on seeing her bag, but the needle and thread belong to her livelihood of repairing nets and baskets. Sabina assists in the search for the missing child; she does not accept criminal responsibility on behalf of her community.

Even when a possibly relevant sandal strap is picked up, it is not called 'the child's proven possession'; Naira writes 'possible object'. When Lata and Janaki reach the assistance room, the official gives them a separate missing-person report, with its time and reference number. Potential routes are to be searched, but Mithun has not been found. The accusation against Janaki's troupe is not automatically appended to this new report. A second application demands correction of the viral image's false time context. Janaki herself removes excessively broad language such as 'everyone lied', insisting that the wording say no more than the evidence supports.

Examining Evidence: Perception, Time, Pervasion and Social Prejudice

The examination of evidence here means more than the assertion that 'there are more documents'. Between the subject—the alleged involvement of Janaki's troupe—the proposition to be established—the abduction of a specific child—and the stated reason—a child's hand and the cry 'Catch them!' in an incomplete video—no necessary concomitance has been demonstrated. That same alleged reason may occur in a crowd, a dispute at the gate, an episode of fear or some entirely separate context; the inference of criminality as presented is therefore inconclusive, or anaikantika. The original video aligns the timing of one historical scene; it does not certify the entire conduct of the troupe. Conversely, Mithun's continued absence does not justify the baseless accusation against Janaki's group. Conflating the two cases would entangle the distinct subjects of evidence. The final two envelopes provide a visual consequence of this difference.

Durga, Mira, Fakira and Sabina rely on different sources of knowledge. Durga knows the schedule of her vehicle, Fakira the station bells and the rhythms of earning a living, Mira the school register, and Sabina the materials of her craft. None of these sources identifies Mithun's present physical whereabouts. This shared distribution of evidence is the novel's achievement: the characters' voices matter because they acknowledge the limits of what they know. It would also be wrong to infer from unavailable information or the statement 'I did not see it' that no such event could have occurred. The author repeatedly keeps the investigative question open.

The Social Perspective: The Right to Search and the Lives of an Accused Community

Not publishing photographs of the children travelling with Janaki's itinerant troupe is more than a rule of privacy: it is a matter of immediate social safety. The crowd's demand—'Bring the child out in front'—would turn a child's body into an exhibit offered in defence against an accusation. Janaki rejects the demand while cooperating in the search. Here a woman's right is not merely the right 'to receive sympathy' but the right to choose the process of verification. Lata is distressed about her genuinely missing son. It would be ethically indefensible to strip Janaki's group of its human rights in the name of alleviating Lata's suffering.

Durga's bamboo, half of Sabina's wages still unpaid, Mira's purchase of classroom supplies from her own earnings and Saryu's khichdi are four strands of work integral to the story's causality. The crowd's insistence that 'the bamboo can wait' reveals a tendency to subordinate livelihood during social crisis; yet Durga's transport time itself becomes evidence. Sabina does

not renounce payment for her work because she offers unpaid assistance with the search. Cooperation and unpaid service are not identical. To an extent, the novel avoids turning working characters into puppets who deliver lectures on duty. Nevertheless, numerous people explain their evidentiary limits with extraordinary precision within the same day, creating a tension between the realism of the prose and the form of a shastrartha, or disciplined debate.

Focalisation, Duration and the Pathos of the Ending

The third-person narration chiefly observes Naira's remorse and Janaki's insecurity, but Lata's helplessness redirects the narrative centre from disproving an allegation towards an actual search. The railway square, forest gate, market, northern lane, assistance room and Sarita's kitchen appear within one day's sequence. Brief exchanges produce temporal distinctions among the acts of 'seeing', 'forwarding', 'recording' and 'searching'. Some details, such as the sandal strap, are only possibilities; their return creates expectations of future inquiry, not accomplished findings.

The final pair of envelopes structurally opposes the single viral headline at the beginning. One envelope contains the contextual correction of the false accusation; the other the report for the search for Mithun. The original page containing 'Twenty-Seven Names' remains in its separate secure place. Outside, children eat khichdi and fall asleep, while at Lata's house a plate remains covered for Mithun. This image of rice recalls the kitchen's material evidence of life in Chapter 1: alongside the necessity of documents, bodily hunger and the pain of absence continue. Karuna rasa emerges from the plate awaiting the missing child; instead of a solution, the chapter offers the next morning's search.

Critical achievement and limitation. The main achievement is the firm separation of the correction of a rumour's context from the actual search for a child, alongside resistance to assigning guilt on the basis of caste or community. One limitation is that nearly every sympathetic participant in the investigation speaks with the same vocabulary of evidentiary caution. The method of correcting falsehood becomes clear, but the complex mentality of a frightened crowd is developed less fully. Another limitation is that the real administrative time required to investigate numerous routes in a single day is compressed into short scenes. The answer to these criticisms is that, despite this speed, the writer does not invent the false triumph of finding Mithun. The chapter concludes with the next day's search and the incomplete reconstruction of social trust, not with the capture of a 'thief'.

Chapter 30 — Ahalya's Voice

The Empty Plate and the Red Circle: The Collision of Two Unequal Injuries

The first scene of this chapter shows morning sunlight falling upon the covered rice Lata has kept for Mithun. Her inability to wash the plate makes the continuing presence of the missing child in memory tangible. She asks those searching for him to go towards the market, not to her house. The novel thereby dramatises one limit of administrative concern: appearing repeatedly at a family's threshold in the name of duty is no substitute for searching. Naira brings two distinct applications, but Lata looks only at the time recorded on the missing-person report. 'The search began earlier' and 'the official report bears this time' are not identical; Naira accepts that she cannot erase the difference.

A red circle appears on a blurred photograph pasted to a market wall: parts of a man and two children's bodies, no government seal, but an air of 'Warning'. The community label 'Kanjar' occupies the position of an accusation. People are taking it for an official notice although its written provenance is unauthenticated. Naira stops as she raises her phone: retransmitting the charge to investigate it could cause fresh harm to the personal faces shown. She first transcribes the wording into her notebook. This scene is a progressive consequence of her error in publishing Mahesh's information in Chapter 20. Remorse is now changing her journalistic procedure.

Mohan is repairing a handcart wheel; the crowd treats him as a 'suspect' before considering his social identity on its own terms. His three slips establish dates and places of cart work. Naira herself clarifies that they are evidence of the cart's work, not proof of every child's movements throughout an entire day. Mohan's statement, 'I recognise my cart', is a limited identification, not a confession to an offence. An unusual strength of the chapter is that the accused person is not made to proclaim his innocence through an impossibly omnipotent dramatic declaration. His right is to have the time and original source of the material on which the accusation rests examined.

Sajid's Recording: Composition, Permission for Use and Corrected Context

Sajid Nat comes to the market carrying colourful theatrical cloth and a camera. He discovers that a portion of an old rehearsal recording has circulated without his name. But he does not immediately publish the original file: the children's guardians gave permission for rehearsals and a

performance, not unlimited retransmission in the market. Naira accepts conditions specifying the purpose in writing and limiting the viewing. Sajid's event receipt records the venue, fee and school schedule; Mohan's cart had indeed been hired to carry theatrical supplies. Even so, one receipt cannot immediately establish the exact date of the photograph. The decision is subsequently strengthened by comparing the original recording with classroom attendance.

The controlled viewing is the chapter's principal turn of events. In the original recording, there are the bamboo gate of the stage, a red curtain, Mohan's cart and children acting. This footage is different from the viral forest-gate video concerning Janaki's troupe; Mithun's disappearance also occurred on a separate day. Mira correlates classroom attendance with the dates on Sajid's event receipt. This evidence overturns the claim of a direct connection between the 'stage photograph' and Mithun's abduction. The person who drew the red circle remains unidentified. Rather than saying too broadly that 'Mohan has been proved innocent of every crime', Mohan himself has written down: 'This picture does not establish an accusation.' Naira's carefully limited summary is the chapter's ethical victory.

With the market shopkeeper's consent, the misleading photograph is removed. In its place goes general contact information and search times, authorised by Lata, without any face presented as suspicious. This change actually takes place. Yet three questions remain open: how many phones retain the old photograph, whether the full effect of the stigma upon the community has disappeared, and whether the author of the defamatory caption has been identified. Sajid's wages for artistic work are still outstanding as well; the organiser uses the viral circulation as an excuse to defer payment. Sajid treats permission to use a recording and payment for labour as distinct matters. The social cost of correction enters the story not only as wounded dignity but also as money still owed.

Ahalya's Ancient Timeline: The Story of Redemption Versus the Right to Be Heard

In the midst of the modern scenes Naira recalls the Ahalya story that Sarita once told her. The novel then constructs an independent scene in an ancient hermitage. Ahalya wipes a platform plastered with earth and cow dung. She knows the hermitage's seasons and the arrangements for water, food and sacrificial fuel. After a visitor arrives, differing allegations concern disguise, identity and Gautama's anger. The story does not supply a uniform verdict of guilt. Ahalya herself distinguishes fear, confusion and uncertainty within her recollection. It would be improper to call this Ahalya the literal voice of the original Ramayana; she belongs to the author's later imaginative rereading.

Calling Ahalya a 'stone' or a 'sinful woman' has the effect of making her food, labour, fear and self-narration appear unnecessary. When Rama and Lakshmana arrive, outsiders immediately proclaim that she has been 'redeemed'. Ahalya, however, asks Rama whether the story circulated about her has been accepted as truth without her being heard. Rama replies, 'I am standing here to listen.' In this rewriting, the right to respond rather than the instant of touch changes the sequence of the story. An elderly woman bears witness to Ahalya's work maintaining the hermitage well and its water rope. This local memory of labour prevents Ahalya's life from being reduced to a narrative of accusation.

The writer redirects 'redemption' from a one-sided declaration to acceptance through dialogue. But this ancient scene is not historical evidence of a modern judicial hearing. Rama's silence, Ahalya's questions and the older woman's local knowledge are actions within the novel's imagined world, not direct quotations from the original classical text. The scene is powerful as a political and ethical symbol, but a separate examination of the many versions of the traditional story would be needed. The novel does not provide an academically exhaustive account of those textual variants, and the criticism makes no such claim.

Narrative Time, Focalisation and the Interaction of Voices

The chapter shifts from one contemporary day of searching to an extended time in the ancient hermitage, then returns to the market. The Ahalya episode is not an incidental didactic footnote. The perspective of a woman who asks questions herself, rather than occupying the place of a person accused by society, alters the narrative situation. In the modern setting Lata directs the search for her child by questioning; Mohan specifies the limits of defective evidence; Sajid respects children's privacy despite owning the recording; and Janaki raises questions of her troupe's safety. One thread runs through these different voices: how far can a person retain the authority to tell their own life while enclosed within another's inference? Yet treating Ahalya, Mohan or Lata as one another's historical equivalents would diminish the complexity of the text.

Intertextuality yields a structural advantage but also carries a danger. Ancient Ahalya speaks in a highly modern language of evidentiary caution and self-representation. This sharply counters the tradition of her silence, but the ancient scene may appear excessively organised according to present-day linguistic and ethical expectations. Contemporary characters, too, arrive very quickly at the right, carefully qualified formulation; the fear and conflicted uncertainties of the search for Mithun could have been elaborated further. The novel lessens the force of this objection by allowing Lata's waiting to continue even after the false poster has been removed.

The Consequences of Public Correction and the Suggestion of the Final Plate

A water seller in the northern lane says that a boy in a blue kurta passed that morning, not the previous day; he did not notice a sandal strap. One confusion about time has been corrected, but Mithun's present location has not been found. Lata apologises to Mohan for her family's wrongful treatment of him. Mohan says they can talk once the boy is found; Lata, however, makes clear that the injustice done to Mohan cannot be deferred indefinitely while she waits for Mithun. In this statement, repairing a relationship and searching for a child become parallel and mutually irreplaceable tasks.

The final plate is covered again at Lata's house; it has been moved from the threshold further inside the kitchen. The false red circle has been removed, but marks of glue remain. The empty plate and the poster's adhesive are two distinct forms of memory: the first, waiting for someone absent; the second, the residue of social humiliation. From the standpoint of Indian poetics, suggestion through these objects gives the experience of karuna greater staying power than a speech announcing a conclusion. Here the Maithili novel's achievement is to keep the human irreducibility of absence alive alongside limited corrections of evidence. The demonstrable outcome of Chapter 30 is removal of the false image and refutation of the basis for a particular accusation—not Mithun's return.

Chapter 31 — Ekalavya's Lesson

The Morning After the Red Circle: A Frame That Shows the World Outside It

On the morning after the false photograph has been removed in Chapter 30, Sajid brings not his camera but an empty wooden frame. The "lesson" of the title initially concerns not another exercise in archery but a visual exercise for the children in the limits of an image. Placing Birsi inside the frame and Jatan outside it, Sajid asks whom a photograph would leave out. The children say "Jatan"; Reva adds that it would also omit the artisan who made his basket. The limit of an image becomes a question not simply of a body situated outside its boundaries but of the invisible labour that makes what is pictured possible. The decision to keep the camera switched off matters: education begins with the discipline of looking, not with making a new recording without permission.

The class held on a temporary veranda is not equivalent to lawful enrolment in a school. Meera marks the names but maintains a distinction between attendance and admission. Reva Gulgulia arrives with her children Birsi and Jatan; their encampment has no permanent address. She possesses a list identifying their shared temporary settlement and an attendance slip from the teaching sessions at their previous location. Meera allows the children to sit in the class, while making clear that the official question of a permanent address remains unresolved. Reva's refusal to invent a "false house number" is the central ethical event here: opening a path to rights must not require manufacturing false evidence.

Chanda Munda's entrance opens a second narrative sequence. Her attendance in construction work has been recorded in different forms—once as "Chanda," elsewhere only by a labourer's serial number. Two slips, a knot in a rope, a measuring tape, a screw and a supply receipt attest to her work, but the original attendance record remains with the contractor. She wants the unpaid wages investigated and insists on retaining control over her decision to return home. Naira does not photograph her slips without permission. She writes down that Chanda will keep the originals and that copies will be made only for a specified application. This is not merely a recollection of Naira's error in Chapter 20; it is a credible change in her conduct.

Register of Events: From Repairing Materials to Valuing Instruction

A screw in the wooden frame is loose. Recognising the danger, Chanda tightens the joint with the proper tool and then shakes it to test it. Yet the need for a new screw remains at the chapter's end: the day begins with a

minor correction, not a completed repair. This small distinction exemplifies the novel's honesty about time. Mohan calculates the hire of his cart; Sajid calculates the work of dramatic training; Chanda raises the safety of tools. Meera asks in which account one should enter the learner's daily food and the value of the instructor's time. This question supplies the causal connection to the Ekalavya scene in the forest.

The ancient episode of Ekalavya does not stop at the well-known moment of the guru's fee. The novel imagines Ekalavya after he has surrendered his thumb, attempting to hold a bowstring, experiencing the daily disability caused by the wound, and being asked by a new pupil, "What will you teach now?" Rather than first constructing an image of devotion to the guru, the narrative sets out the realities of bodily loss: the slipping string, an arrow falling short and the blow of the wood. Ekalavya neither conceals the injury nor dissolves it into a sermon on noble sacrifice. His admission that "the skill which has diminished has diminished" resists a miraculous restoration of the hero.

The elderly woman who makes bowstrings is a major critical voice in the ancient narrative strand. Her question—what will the learner's household eat?—turns the discussion from an instructor's prestige toward the material organisation of life. Ekalavya teaches how to judge the straightness of bamboo, the tension of a string, the presence of living creatures beyond a target and the recognition of mistakes. No miracle returns his old proficiency with the arrow; the pupil adapts skill to new forms of work. Food shares, a common stock of materials, the string-maker's wages and payment for the teacher's time become separate accounts. Later the pupil's first earnings come not from a successful hunt but from making a string. In paying the teacher, the pupil distinguishes payment for a name from payment for time spent teaching. In this narrative recasting, guru-dakshina is no longer the sole moral category: equitable remuneration for labour becomes central.

This passage must not be mistaken for a documentary account of Ekalavya's unknown historical life after the Mahabharata episode. It is the novelist's imagined sequel, constructed through modern ethical questions about schooling, labour and disability. The critical question is whether the bodily loss remains permanent after the mythic event is transformed. Here it does: Meera expressly tells the children that Ekalavya's hand did not return to its former condition; he found new work and new pupils. That incompleteness checks, to some extent, the manufactured miracle of an inspirational story.

Entry into Modern Education: Temporary Attendance, Formal Rights and the Limits of the Register

On returning from the ancient story, Birsi asks whether the target can be struck again; but the decisive modern question concerns the children's formal school admission. Meera brings the list requiring a permanent address and refuses to treat an official's oral statement as the final legal rule. Two applications are prepared: one concerning temporary attendance arrangements and another requesting the written procedure for admission without a permanent address. Seeking a written reply does not mean that the government has changed its regulations; an administrative process has merely begun. The mismatch between Reva's mobile encampment and the fixed boxes in the school register produces a particular urban-poverty chronotope: the child's name stays the same, the household moves, while the state's register expects a fixed address.

Jatan's reversed letter "ja" is more than a sentimental detail. Birsi tries to rub out his writing; Reva stops her. Meera writes the correct letter alongside it without erasing the first. The child's original mistake becomes a trace of the history of his learning. The comparison with Ekalavya's wound must be cautious: both are not "errors." One is an ordinary stage in learning, the other permanent bodily damage imposed as punishment. Their literary connection lies in accepting an incomplete state, not in equating their causes. Jatan's page is no adult admission certificate, yet erasing it would destroy part of the educational process's memory.

The practical limits of Chanda's training become explicit. She refuses to teach the children knots intended to bear the load of an elevated platform; she allows only exercises without weight. Meera enters an hour's training fee in the account. Some object to paying for "two knots"; Reva asks them to tie the knots themselves, and their failure reveals the specialised nature of the skill. Mohan makes a small advance contribution, while the balance must still be checked against the collective fund. Thus the payment has been agreed in advance, but full payment has not been established. The cause of the deductions from Chanda's construction wages remains blank; her final account of arrears has not been settled.

Two-Time Narration, Women's Knowledge and Ethical Form

The ancient scene opens out of the question of instruction raised by the modern wooden frame; the return to the present is marked by Meera's answer to the children. Although the prevailing narrative voice is third-person and Naira's memory of her wrongdoing remains important, the classroom's focalisation is distributed among Ekalavya, Meera, Reva, Chanda, Sajid and the children. In Ekalavya's case, "justice" does not mean only mourning a previous insult; it is the uncertain question of how

education can be organised after an injury. The modern lesson distinguishes demand, teaching method, safety, time, remuneration and consent to an image. This reciprocal construction draws ideas from the story instead of merely searching for examples to illustrate pre-existing ideas.

At the end Naira keeps four records separate: Chanda's application concerning wages and returning home; Reva's school correspondence concerning her children; a distinct missing-person file for Mithun; and Sarita's protected twenty-seven names. Treating "all the papers as one problem" would collapse the wishes of different people, accusations of wrongdoing and claims of rights into the same linguistic category. The question of a source's relevance is a suitable test in narratological analysis: the purpose of one application cannot be extended automatically to the objective of another applicant.

Critical achievement and limitation. The chapter brings into view four distinctions: formal access to education and temporary practice; the prestige of the guru and the worth of instruction; visual evidence and private consent; and the rights arising from each. Reva and Chanda are not supporting illustrations but agents in decisions about their own lives. Nevertheless, many of ancient Ekalavya's speeches express modern labour-contract procedures with excessive neatness. This is a conscious technique of post-epic rereading, yet it narrows the differences of historical language. In a single day, the camera lesson, register dispute, wage application and rope training all become a succession of ethically lucid moments; there is comparatively little pause for the characters' inner uncertainty. The chapter ends between Jatan's reversed letter and the possibility of another unexplained change of encampment during the night: it offers the uncertain continuity of education, not reassurance.

Chapter 32 — Now, Whose Inquiry?

The First Letter of the Question: Distinguishing Error, Eligibility and Exclusion

The chapter opens with Jatan's reversed "ja." Meera writes the correct letter without erasing the first mark and explains that showing a mistake is not the same as excluding the person who made it. Through this childhood incident, the "whose" of the title ceases to be merely the name of a philosophical subject. It becomes a critical question about the person authorised to inquire and the modern institutional conditions under which inquiry is permitted. Birsi draws a house: its site may change, but its imagined dwelling remains secure on paper. An uncertain address does not

prevent attendance in the class, even though it raises a practical dispute concerning the school's permanent register.

The school clerk provides a stamped written reply: verification of a permanent address is pending; there is no final order concerning participation in class. This is neither formal enrolment nor written expulsion. Reva immediately asks where the children will study in the meantime. Meera proposes continuing the temporary class and raising the matter again with the headteacher. The evidentiary precision of this beginning grounds the later examination of brahmajijnasa, the desire to inquire into Brahman: "reply pending" does not mean "eligibility disproved." To declare a child's wish to learn meaningless on the basis of a procedural pause recorded in a letter would be an inference that fails to cover what it claims.

A second narrative line concerns Maithili Mishra's public reading session. The invitation prefixes her name only with "respected," while Ishan receives editorial and scholarly credentials alongside his name. Maithili objects not to a word of courtesy but to the unequal recording of kinds of work and scholarly credit. Harimohan Pathak stresses preparation, variant readings and the discipline of grammar. Maithili does not reject discipline; she asks how it can be just to close the door to initial practice and subsequently accuse the excluded of incompetence. The discussion distinguishes "give everyone a specialised manuscript without preparation" from "open access to the means of preparation."

The institution's work schedule records copying, cleaning, preparing seats, repairing paper and hours of reading, but remuneration appears only against copying. Maithili asks whether the other tasks are voluntary contributions or labour for which payment is due; if voluntary, where has consent been recorded? Education and credit thereby cease to concern only "abstract rights to knowledge": they involve the material contribution of those who sustain the institution. Reva's children seek "a place to learn their first letters" in the reading school, separately from their formal application to the state school. Harimohan initially confuses these two situations, then revises his objection after understanding the difference. The fragility of old manuscripts is acknowledged; the possibility of giving the children safe practice sheets emerges later.

Mrinal, Lohana and Vachaspati: Material Knowledge in the Ancient Time-Strand

From the thirteenth textual passage onward, the story enters another time in ancient Mithila. Mrinal dries wet sheets of paper; Lohana explains the practical reason for keeping them out of direct sunlight and in moving air under shade. Mrinal counts manuscripts, clears away dust and works to

preserve their letters, while experiencing herself as excluded from the right to ask questions in the school. Lohana asks about payment for paper and the hours of her labour; Mrinal seeks a path to reading. This ancient scene is a modern imaginative narrative extension of the philosophical tradition associated with Bhamati, not a verified episode from Vachaspati Mishra's life or a quotation from the original treatise.

Vachaspati discusses the opening words of the Brahma Sutras, "athato brahmajijnasa." The pupils ask different questions about the order, purpose and eligibility implied by "atha" and "atah." Mrinal does not understand every sutra, but on hearing "inquiry" asks how a sequence leading to inquiry can be made available when the student already trained in scripture and a beginner learning to join letters stand at different stages. One disciple insists upon the necessity of qualification, another upon traditional sequence. Mrinal does not oppose preparation: she demands an opportunity to learn how to prepare. Her reasoning is that closing the route to training and then making the absence of training evidence of permanent ineligibility creates a self-confirming institutional circle.

Vachaspati does not treat Mrinal's experience as immediately decisive proof of the sutra's philosophical proposition. He first asks them to test the limits within which an illustration applies. When the familiar analogy of mistaking a rope for a snake is raised, Mrinal asks about ink spreading across damp paper: in that instance, is the viewer mistaken, has the condition of the object altered, or is the reader insufficiently prepared? The teacher accepts the distinction: a mistaken perception of the rope and a material alteration of paper are not the same. This is the precise turning point in the textual criticism. Once the social question of access to inquiry and the philosophical question of the causes of knowledge are separately recognised, analogy begins to alter an argument rather than serving as ceremonial display.

Vachaspati hears the question raised in the eighteenth passage, but the text does not conclude that Mrinal has "understood the entire meaning of the Brahma Sutras." What immediately emerges is the need to redistribute the labour-time spent drying paper so that time for reading can exist. Lohana considers asking another assistant to come the following day, so that Mrinal's reading hour will not simply be imposed upon another unpaid worker. Permission to sit and an assured period for learning the letters are two different achievements. The actual social cost of philosophical debate remains part of the narrative's purpose.

Debate in the Present-Day Reading School: Keeping the Sutra and Policy Distinct

When the modern scene resumes, Maithili makes clear that "athato brahmajijnasa" is not a government school admission regulation and that the classical sutra cannot directly supply a legal verdict on present educational policy. Harimohan draws two columns on the board: "interpretation of scripture" and "today's dispute about access." In the first he writes text, the opposing position and its reply; in the second, materials, beginner's classes, instructor, time and fees. This is the chapter's strongest intellectual discipline: intertextuality becomes a resonance between questions, not an authoritative source of law. Jatan's "Which column am I in?" exposes the hidden power of that classification through an ordinary child's question.

Chanda Munda offers the example of light training before handling heavy tools. This is not an order to let everyone directly handle a fragile manuscript. It seeks an appropriate balance between protection of the text and availability of practice. Harimohan proposes safe exercise sheets. Mistakes on the children's paper do not annul their right to learn, but the vulnerability of a manuscript must not become a false excuse for discrimination. Compared with the preceding Ahalya and Ekalavya chapters, this two-sided caution here assumes a more explicitly reasoned and procedural form.

Maithili displays two copies: one bears a marginal note, which is missing from the other. An author's signature alone is insufficient evidence explaining the difference; comparison with the original is needed. She demands separate recording of the copyist's, checker's and annotator's names, the nature of their contributions and their dates. Harimohan accepts the difference between original argument and checking a copy; Maithili accepts that difference but refuses erasure of the latter contribution. The discussion does not conclude with the simplistic demand to call everyone an equally credited author. It insists upon identifying each distinct contribution through evidence. Ishan undertakes to verify the date of the old manuscript.

Naira recommends separating attendance from consent to publish a copy. In particular, a child's presence in class does not constitute permission to publish the child's photograph. This recommendation demonstrates the narrative's long continuity: Naira's earlier error in carelessly publishing Mahesh's confidential statement now has critical consequences for the rules of another institution. Yet Naira does not become its supreme authority; her proposal enters the procedures of Harimohan and the organisers. The allocation of decision-making power thus becomes, to a degree, polycentric.

Record of Decisions: What Change Is Verified, and What Remains Pending?

Three decisions at the end of the meeting are explicit: beginner's practice sheets will be distributed; a separate register will record the children's temporary attendance; and the school's written response on formal admission remains outstanding. If Chanda is invited to teach another practical class, the participants agree to fix her instructional fee in advance. Harimohan signs the proposal. A separate register of contributions is opened with empty columns for revision, copying, linguistic comparison, examples and final approval. Names are not entered immediately; they will be added after checking. No final decision has been made on Maithili's individual scholarly credit: the dispute has become a recorded question. These are different levels of narrative outcome, not one completed "reform."

Harimohan gives Birsi a light practice book. Because moving the encampment may change where the book can be returned, he avoids imposing a fixed return date. Jatan preserves both his first reversed "ja" and the new correctly written letter. This simple act brings together the successive time of learning, the pupil's preservation of his own error and the portability of knowledge within precarious housing. Yet the educational difference is not merely a display of two letters. The notation "reply pending" on the school paper keeps the distance between progress in learning and legal permission unmistakable.

Temporal Strata, Evidence and Aesthetic Analysis

The chapter begins with letter practice at a modern dawn, moves to the public reading school, opens an ancient Mithila episode featuring Mrinal and Vachaspati, and then presents the result of the present-day debate; near its end it briefly returns to a memory of Mrinal's labour on the old veranda. This symmetrical movement is not decorative mythology. It tests a present-day counterargument against a question raised in another temporal strand. The third-person narrator distributes knowledge among the neglect of Maithili's credit, Reva's uncertain address, Mrinal's limited ability to read and Harimohan's hesitation. No character supplies a complete scriptural or institutional solution in a single scene.

From the standpoint of propriety or aucitya in Indian poetics, the wet page, the rope-and-snake example, letters written in chalk and a missing marginal annotation serve, at different levels, as metaphors for access to and loss of knowledge. But the spreading of ink is a change in the object; perceiving a snake where there is a rope is a false perception. The novelist explicitly maintains that distinction. To infer "no certificate, therefore no qualification" may be invalid within the narrative's evidentiary inquiry,

but this critic's analytical vocabulary must not be presented as a verbatim sutra in Vachaspati's commentary. Problems of deceit, error, conditions, access and recognition in the novel invite philosophical reconsideration; they are not simplified substitutes for classical philosophical meanings.

Critical achievement and limitation. The chapter's strength lies in marking out the limits of three matters before joining them under an evidentiary discipline: philosophical inquiry into Brahman, the modern right to elementary education and disagreement about contributions to a manuscript. Mrinal draws from her own experience to expose a faulty analogy; Maithili seeks a verifiable register rather than demanding an immediate final ruling on credit; Harimohan accepts practice sheets while retaining the issue of protecting original texts. One limitation is the unusually explicit language of modern institutional equality in the ancient debate, which can blur the historical differences. Another is the gathering of so many orderly written decisions at one final meeting, while the time of real institutional resistance receives less attention. Nevertheless, the three final notations—"temporary attendance," "reply pending" and "beginner's lessons"—do not substitute for one another, preventing a manufactured happy ending.

Vana Parva / Aranya Kanda: Comparative Criticism of Chapters 29–32

From Two Days of Crowds to a School Across Two Times: The Causal Sequence

The viral video of the gate in Chapter 29 arises from the dispute over the forest route in Chapter 28. When it is examined in context, one unverified accusation against Janaki's group is weakened, but Mithun's disappearance enters as a new and real crisis. Chapter 30 adds to that crisis the wrongly identified photograph of a performance circled in red at the market. Sajid's original rehearsal recording undermines the specific accusation against Mohan based on that image. It is precisely this experience that leads Sajid in Chapter 31 to teach "inside/outside the frame." Reva's children and Chanda's wage dispute enter that class; the written response concerning formal admission and the question of public scholarly debate in Chapter 32 emerge causally from those preceding events. The story is not a collection of disconnected social entries: one incomplete outcome provides the starting point for the next situation. Still, the regularity with which every new character promptly raises a relevant ethical question suggests a possible mechanical quality in the composition. (Original Chapters 28–32.)

Differences of Time, Dual Temporalities and the Function of Repetition

Chapter 29 occupies approximately one modern day of inquiry; its opening label "this morning" distorts the event of "yesterday evening." Chapter 30 moves from the time of the present search into Ahalya's extended ancient ashram time and returns to the modern market. Chapter 31 has a three-part flow: the modern temporary veranda, Ekalavya's imagined subsequent life and another lesson on the veranda. Chapter 32 makes a more complex recurrence: the modern class, Vachaspati and Mrinal's debate in ancient Mithila, the modern reading school and a brief return to the old veranda. It would be inaccurate to homogenise these arrangements by saying that "all four chapters have two timelines": Chapter 29 essentially investigates a rumour in a single modern day. (Chapters 29–32.)

Recurring objects do not all carry one meaning that transcends their material differences. The incorrect video, poster marked with a red circle, empty camera frame, first reversed "ja" and divergent margins of two manuscripts all point to limits of seeing and writing, but they do not have identical legal consequences. The plate covered for Mithun expresses a sense of his absence; glue left by the poster marks the residue of a stigma; Jatan's page preserving his error records the history of learning; Mrinal's wet paper presents a material obstacle to preserving knowledge. Their artistic force lies in allowing these different objects to become symbols without erasing their physical specificity.

Narrative Evidence and the Limits of Epic Intertextuality

Two false public accusations require a common method of investigation: who made the assertion, when its image was made, who possesses the original, what the evidence actually covers, and how far it reaches toward imputing guilt to a person or community. But Durga's transportation receipt or Sajid's event receipt cannot by itself establish the whole world of events. The explicit correction achieved in Chapters 29–30 is limited to "this evidence does not prove theft" or "this photograph does not prove Mohan's wrongdoing"; it does not conclude the search for Mithun. In Chapters 31–32 the evidentiary question assumes new forms: temporary attendance versus lawful enrolment, a work slip versus final liability for deductions, inherited scholarly credit versus a verified register of contributions.

The Ahalya, Ekalavya and Vachaspati–Mrinal scenes are the novel's imaginative rewritings. Ahalya's right to be heard after "deliverance," Ekalavya's material survival after losing his thumb and Mrinal's right to practise letters do not turn these ancient figures into literal replicas of modern problems. The similarity concerns the form of ethical questions;

texts, times and historical evidence remain distinct. The original philosophical purpose of "athato brahmajijnasa," associated with the Bhamati tradition, is not a modern school-admission rule: the novel itself says so. This explicit boundary gives intertextuality its legitimacy, although the modern institutional vocabulary placed in ancient mouths remains an artistic difficulty.

Women's Voices, Community Names and the Practical Meaning of Labour

The right to shield the face of a child accused by Janaki's group, Lata's genuine anxiety in her search, Sabina's insistence that caste does not prove criminality, Reva's determination not to invent an address, Chanda's authority to determine the hazards and fee of instruction, Maithili's demand for evidence of credit, and Mrinal's wish for time to study are all different rights expressed through action. The number of women characters alone does not establish polyphony; their different interests and disagreements matter. Lata wants Mithun's search continued even after a photograph is removed. Janaki primarily wants the innocent children of her group protected. Chanda retains control over the choice of returning home. These distinctions constitute the ethical substance of the prose. (Chapters 29–32.)

Nor does labour fall into the same economic category everywhere. Durga's transportation slip supplies evidence of time; half of Sabina's payment remains due; permission to use Sajid's recording and payment for organising an event are distinct disputes; Chanda's instructional fee is agreed in advance, but the contractor's arrears remain undecided; Mrinal's study hour must be reconciled with the additional labour of Lohana and an assistant. Without these specific differences, a declaration that "the novel celebrates the dignity of labour" would be a formula of praise rather than a critique of narrative events.

Interim Assessment and the Limits of the Present Reading

A remarkable achievement of these four chapters is their resistance to extravagant proclamations of rescue through small, verified, partial changes. Mithun remains missing though one basis for an accusation is corrected. The false poster has been removed, but traces of humiliation remain. Reva's children are learning, but have not received formal admission. Payment for Chanda's teaching time is agreed, but her original arrears are not cleared. A register of contributions has opened, but credit has not finally been allotted. The ethical reasoning of the plot is thus controlled by the limits of its results. Potential formal weaknesses should also be named with evidence: repeated statements separating kinds of proof, the similarly mature ethical voices of many characters and the

excessive neatness of their carefully earned conclusions. The return of certain symbols and unfinished decisions creates artistic unity; if repetition ceases to add meaning, however, it risks becoming didactic. This discussion covers Vana Parva only through Chapters 25–32. No final judgement on the whole parva is possible without reading Chapters 33–36.

Chapter 33 — The Lamp and the Paper

The Time Taken to Make Paper: The Visible Scripture and the Invisible Time of the Artisan

The chapter begins not with Mrinal's question about study but with Lohana measuring water into two trays. Clear water in one and water mixed with fibres in the other show different stages of manufacture. At first Mrinal tries to straighten the beaten fibres by hand; Lohana explains that pressing the wet fibres forcibly will make knots. Mrinal learns the practical knowledge of tilting the frame, observing the direction of flowing water and spreading the fibres evenly instead of intervening impatiently with her hands. This opportunity for instruction is not an incidental symbol. Manuscripts cannot be copied without making paper, yet traditional accounts of the scriptures rarely show the labour of paper-making taking its own time. The opening scene extends the right to philosophical debate towards the hands that make its material medium.

After a night with the lamp, Bhamati observes a smoke-stained sheet, an empty oil bowl and irritated eyes. A disciple praises the religious merit of "service to scripture"; Bhamati checks that general ethic of service with separate accounts of expense, health and rest. Four pages are immediately ready, but two will have to be dried again. This numerical scene questions the temptation to represent progress without its cost. To Bhamati's three lines for pages made, spoiled and saved, Lohana adds a fourth: "time spent working." This small addition shifts focalisation from the finished material copy of a book towards the human duration required to produce it. Bhamati speaks as a disciplined manager of the household, Lohana as an artisan, and Vachaspati as an adjudicator of readings; their positions are not interchangeable.

Showing a torn sieve, Lohana distinguishes the cost of materials from arrears of wages. There is no scene in which Vachaspati instantly pays everything; the practical limit on making smaller sheets before market day is acknowledged. Later Lohana reports receiving half her wages and insists on recording a date and a measured amount of grain against the remainder. Particularly significant is the substitution of "balance due" for "assistance." The change in wording is not merely grammatical: it attempts to turn a donor–recipient relationship into an obligation owed

by an employer to a worker. Vachaspati marks the entry, but Lohana demands that the line be read aloud to her. Here a document's authority depends on understanding its content and having the right to correct it, not merely on the presence of a signature.

The Incomplete Line "Kritasara": Textual Criticism and the Limits of Knowledge

Mrinal encounters the word "Kritasara" in a new copy. Its surrounding words have been cut away; someone, observing a reference to water, suggests it is the name of a river. Mrinal asks why the fact that a page has been soaked should automatically make the word written on it mean "river." Vachaspati offers no immediate solution; comparison is deferred until another original copy can be found. Bhamati makes a special mark in the page's margin. This is an important scene of textual criticism: the original is incomplete, the copy is incomplete and the meaning is undecided. None of these states is closed by presenting a scholar's final judgement.

Lohana's reply about measuring the land separately is noteworthy. An incomplete poetic word cannot provide conclusive evidence of the ownership of a ghat or of its geography. In narrative terms, the supporting object, the intended meaning of the word and the proposition being advanced must be separately identified. The presence of a word connected with water does not establish a particular river; identifying a particular river would still require an independent test of rights over the land at its ghat. This is the critic's conceptual reinterpretation, not a verbatim classical aphorism written into the novel. The scene shows that the chapter's philosophy of knowledge does not end in the elevated terminology of Vedanta: it involves a living test of readers' mistaken inferences.

Somri Hembram: Translation, Consent and Unequal Power in the Contract

In modern Videhapur, the first things shown are a dripping tin roof, damp practice sheets and an unpaid repair bill. Within this material problem Somri Hembram arrives with her work slip, a contract translated only halfway and a receipt. Her difficulty is not merely that "an illiterate labourer needs someone to read a document." The paper sets out a daily rate, a condition for relocating accommodation and a deduction for leaving work midway; the consequences for wages when work is suspended by rain remain unclear. Somri refuses to give her thumbprint to that uncertainty. The narrative thereby makes a decisive distinction between acquiring formal literacy and the actual validity of consent.

Meera explains the words in simpler Maithili, but Somri raises another question: not everyone in her work group understands Maithili, so who will pay the person who explains the contract in each worker's mother tongue? Somri does not automatically accept the role of representing all the others. The application specifies four questions: the daily rate, the calculation of time lost to rain, the conditions for moving accommodation and the right to linguistic comprehension. Two copies are made, but obtaining copies does not mean that the contract has been amended. Somri sees a message from the contractor's clerk yet does not immediately assent. Her self-determination develops not because she is free of fear, but because she can make a decision knowing the risk of losing employment.

Somri stops Ishan from climbing onto the wet roof: enthusiasm for work cannot substitute for safety arrangements. In that moment she is not portrayed only as a victim of a contract; her knowledge of construction changes another person's immediate conduct. The roof is not repaired instantaneously. By evening temporary protection with a tarpaulin is in place and a time for safe access the following day has been recorded. This is the direct result in the plot: recognition of a hazard, prevention of immediately dangerous work and temporary protection—not a claim that a permanent roof has been completed.

Narrative Time, the Child's Perspective and the Ethical Meaning of the Lamp

The chapter alternates between morning on the ancient veranda and morning in Videhapur, then moves through afternoon and evening in both periods. The third-person narrator clearly marks the distance of time and place. Focalisation circulates first among Bhamati, Mrinal and Lohana, then among Somri, Maithili, Meera and Sarita. No ancient character literally enters a modern school; resemblance between objects, inequality of labour and the preservation of pages connect the two times at the level of thought. The other temporal strand is not direct historical proof of the modern work schedule but a composed conversation.

A girl from a disciple's family asks where the smoke goes when the light of the lamp is exhausted. Bhamati replies: outside, onto the page and into the breath; reducing the hours for which the lamp burns then becomes a subject of discussion. Vachaspati's promise to reduce night-time copying is not merely symbolic renunciation but a decision to change study hours and allow the eyes to rest. In the modern strand, Birsi and Jatan's wet practice sheets, errors in a small notebook and the plate of food show how preserving paper is connected with future opportunities to learn. The final parallel images—Sarita's covered lamp and Bhamati's trimmed wick—

justify the recurrence, but the social circumstances of the two women are not identical.

Achievement and limitation. The work's strength lies in opening the invisible economy of scriptural production through concrete disputes about objects, wages, rest and consent in language. Bhamati identifies the popular tale about her lamp as a "story"; she does not demand that its account of her eye-straining labour be taken as automatically verified history. This self-limitation matters. Yet the ancient pupil's instant, sensible objection, the modern labourer's carefully considered policy language and the neatly constructed final register frequently make the author's ethical planning audible. Within one day the concentration of sophisticated debate about delicate distinctions of labour, together with small solutions, can make some scenes excessively instructional. That is a legitimate critical reservation. Nevertheless, the remaining wages, ambiguous contract and unsafe roof prevent an inexpensive idealistic ending.

Chapter 34 — The Unseen Cause

The Historical Display Board: Printing Error and Original Archival Exclusion

Hema Dev begins by measuring a wet exhibition board at the school. Beneath pictures of Videhapur's founding, its roads and the dredging of its pond appear the names of ten men and only a collective line for the women. Her question—"On which page are the women's names?"—immediately places the reader between the visible archival object and invisible labour. But the narrative does not treat her initial outrage as a complete conclusion. A copy of a photograph connected to the pond-dredging work of 1939 is preserved by a family, not an original government register. Four possible marks of names along its torn edge do not all have the same evidentiary value. Hema creates separate columns for fully verified names, incomplete names and unnamed labour. The narrator prevents the perception of historical injustice from becoming a claim to identify letters with more certainty than the evidence warrants.

The entrance of Nasima Shershahbadi gives the archive dispute a new material direction. Reinforcing the back of a sheet, preventing damp damage, measuring the actual width of a board and examining the trimmed edge are practical skills by which it becomes clear that certain final letters were lost in printing. Nasima nevertheless states a precise limit: a name never entered in the original list cannot be explained away as a casualty of trimming. Hema revises her first all-embracing accusation. Here a changed premise is an event in the narrative, not merely the

injunction that "one ought to review the evidence." The two different causes—printer's error and exclusion from the register—open a new question for historiography.

Seen through the perspective of Videha's parallel history, "anonymous women's labour" is not simply a pathetic symbol; it concerns unequal rights to be registered in the process of making an archive. Those who prepared food, carried mud and marked the ghat can be sought through family copies or oral memory, but an evidentiary gap cannot be filled with invented names. Sarita explains that recognising that labour was once performed and having proof of a particular worker's name are different matters. Ethical restoration of history and archival verification are not enemies in this account; each requires caution from the other.

Udayana's Debate with a Mimamsaka: Distinguishing the Unseen from the Unproved

In the ancient strand concerning Udayana, a Mimamsaka opponent questions the adequacy of explanations through the fruit of action, apurva or adrishta. His objection is not that an invisible entity must automatically be denied existence, but that an additional conscious cause has not been shown necessary to explain the delay between action and result. A student hastily equates "unseen" with "unproved"; Udayana stops him. An object not seen and a claim without evidence constitute different problems. Inference requires investigation of the relation, the domain of examination and the explanatory adequacy of the opposing account.

When an example is offered of inferring water inside a vessel from its weight even when the water cannot be seen, the visitor points to the example's testability. The regular relation involved in delayed karmic results cannot be established automatically by the experience of weighing a vessel. An elderly potter lists several possible causes for a cracked pot: sand, heat and drying time. Udayana does not promote his observation into proof of a classical hypothesis; he retains it only as a caution about multiple possible causes. The novel respects technical knowledge derived from experience without making an unauthorised leap from a domestic example to a philosophical conclusion. Its strength lies in separating the coherence of an argument about reality from the limits of an illustration.

A pupil's brief copy reduces the visitor's five questions to three. Udayana makes him describe it as "incomplete," not "abridged." A rule for debate is subsequently adopted: repeat the opponent's argument first in a form that the opponent accepts, and only then object to it. The visitor corrects the use of "necessary" and "sufficient"; there is no definite answer that day. Preparing a textual copy is itself a just distribution of knowledge: corrupting an opponent's thought through shortening it does not count as

success in philosophical debate. Udayana's episode is an imaginative example of contemporary ethical reasoning; its dialogue must not be mistaken for a historically authenticated exchange in his original Nyayakusumanjali.

The Labour Receipt, Temporary Notice and Permission to Publish Names

Nasima determines the spelling of her own name. She prepares a receipt separating tools, materials, work hours and hire charges. Her explicit declaration that this is "work," not "help," creates a causal echo of Lohana's amendment in Chapter 33, although the professions and settings differ. The day for payment is written on the receipt; the entire sum has not been paid at once. Before repairing a child's first practice sheet with adhesive, Nasima seeks the mother's permission, raising the larger question of who owns documents. Credit for the artisan, the child's handwriting and the restoration of public history occur in one scene; criticism must hold all three apart even while examining their relation.

Hema's revised historical text will go to a committee for consideration; she does not remove the old display board herself and announce a newly certified history. Nasima attaches a temporary notice stating that the list of names rests on incomplete sources and that verification continues. "Incomplete" here is a public admission of a limit in knowledge, not a defeat. Naira's insistence that Sarita's confidential register of twenty-seven names must not be turned into material for the public history clarifies another distinction between rights in context. An ethical desire to identify neglected historical labour does not automatically authorise disclosure of private records concerning the safety of living people.

Duration, Focalisation and Unequal Metaphors

Modern time in this chapter is principally the time of one day's class, repair work and proposed amendments. Morning, afternoon and night in the ancient debate are progressively interwoven with these modern events. The simultaneity is a rhythm created by editing the narration, not an assertion that the two historical moments physically coincide. Moisture in an ancient pot, a trimmed corner of a modern board, knots in bamboo fibres and a water-damaged copy all help the reader understand the limits of perception. But inference concerning the cause of a broken pot and the historical exclusion of women's names are not facts on the same level. Under the chapter's overarching phrase "unseen causes," the novel maintains their distinctions layer by layer.

Within the third-person narration, Hema revises her initial judgement, Nasima brings specialist knowledge of material evidence, Udayana teaches

the practice of hearing an opposing position, Meera questions the children about incomplete pictures, and Sarita identifies different kinds of oral memory. The multiplicity of questions and replies creates the possibility of polyphony, but genuine polyphony must be sought in the final consequences of disagreement. An older teacher objects to Hema's new history; approval by the management committee is still pending; the Mimamsaka's question remains intact. These differences have not been dissolved in a final ruling.

Achievement and limitation. The principal achievement is treating a name cut off a board, a woman omitted from an original list, a potter's knowledge of multiple causes and the philosophical dispute about "necessity" as matters occupying different evidentiary positions. One limitation is that the ancient debate's ethical conditions and the modern school's procedures for correction appear coordinated almost too neatly. At times the speakers sound less like people experiencing spontaneous uncertainty than like the systematic vocabulary of the critic. Yet Hema's actual revision of her first allegation and Udayana's unfinished answer prevent the sequence from becoming merely a gallery of illustrated ideas.

Chapter 35 — Recognising the Gavaya

The Red Question Mark: Hope in the Search and the Safety of a Person

A freshly pasted sheet on the school veranda shows two blurred images, one from the bus stand and another from the western lane. Half-visible faces, the shadow of a scarf and a question in red ink—"The same man?"—appear beside a reference to the search for Mithun. Although the title evokes the classical example of the gavaya, or wild ox, the opening is governed by the anxiety of Lata, the mother of a genuinely missing child. Meera prevents the photographs from becoming an immediate accusation. Naira recognises the distinct purposes of the community search register and the formal complaint. Lata retains the original complaint; Naira's voluntary assistance register is not a judicial instrument for determining guilt.

The first image contains half the shutter of a tea stall, the second a face concealed by shadow. The person who brought the photograph is unnamed; its source is given only as "was seen." This anonymous speaker matters. If someone says a person "was seen," who is the witness? When was the image taken, by which camera, with what cropped frame, and where is the original copy? None of these questions has an answer. Naira's memory of her earlier publication mistake supplies the psychological background. Her effort not to repeat a hasty and false certainty is a concrete stage in her

character development, although experience has not turned her into an automatically impartial and omniscient observer.

Lata's voice, worn down by the search for her son, tests the investigation. At first Naira's caution seems to Lata like the extinguishing of hope. Later Lata herself asks that the original image be preserved, the label "suspect" removed and a separate statement taken if an actual witness is found. Her decision makes "the victim's wishes" and "the accused person's rights" something other than a zero-sum opposition: the search continues while the public accusation is limited. The original image is placed in a sealed envelope, no face is put on the public notice, and Lata consents to supplying a corrected copy to the official investigator. Those are the chapter's accomplishments. Mithun is not found, the photographed person is not identified, and no offence is proved.

The Gavaya in Analogy: Separating Knowledge of a Word's Meaning from Personal Identification

Meera gives the children the classical example of knowledge through comparison, upamana: hearing that a gavaya resembles a cow and later recognising the meaning of the unfamiliar animal's name on seeing it. She explains that a cow and a gavaya are not the same animal, and that the problem of whether two human images depict the same individual is harder still. Harimohan puts two categories on the board: "relation between word and object" and "identification of a person." The classical proposition is kept within its proper objective: learning what the word "gavaya" means, not deciding that someone is a criminal from a photograph.

In the ancient strand concerning Gangesha, the teacher distinguishes the sequence of hearing a description, seeing the object and grasping the relation of a word to its meaning. The class of an object and the identification of one particular individual are different questions. It would be wrong to call this composed philosophical exchange an authenticated historical conversation from the original Tattvachintamani. The novel uses a philosophical distinction within the limits of a modern social inquiry. The character expressly states that the gavaya example is not designed to catch a thief. This self-imposed boundary reduces the danger of misusing the philosophical intertext; it does not mean that the complex classical controversies about upamana have been resolved by one brief lesson.

Rajo Bhogta offers a practical counterexample to the illusion that two similar-looking planks of wood are one and the same object. Accepting the shopkeeper's reply that "it is wood, not a human being," Rajo argues that greater care is required when identifying a person. Following the

manuscript pages associated with Bhamati and Nasima's cut display board, this is a third intervention through material objects. Expertise belongs not only to philosophical terminology but also to the craft of recognising everyday things. The wooden analogy, however, does not constitute a complete moral theory of guilt and innocence; it is an opportunity to prevent a faulty leap in reasoning.

Two Addresses, One Person: Rajo's Wages and Reva's School Admission

Rajo Bhogta displays proof of an old village residence and a recent rent receipt, with different addresses. The discrepancy has threatened to hold up an application for assistance. Before showing the papers she demands a written statement of their purpose; her consent matters because it remains uncertain whose phone had previously received her copy. At the office, figures from a transport-wages receipt have been wrongly joined to the application for assistance. The head official acknowledges the mistake of combining the two accounts and directs the payment department to review the wages separately. Eligibility for assistance remains undecided, and wages have not been paid into Rajo's hands. Problems of two matching or divergent addresses and of two distinct economic rights intersect in one life, but they do not have the same resolution.

When Reva's question is raised, the children's notebook of temporary class attendance remains separate from the register of formal school admission. Reva refuses to write a fictitious permanent address. The head issues a written order keeping temporary attendance and the decision on admission distinct. The order has not finally implemented the children's right of school access: alternative address verification is deferred to another meeting. Reva's closing question—where will the class take place tomorrow?—lifts educational rights out of the classification of paper into the uncertainty of actual time and place. It supplies the narrative seed for the next chapter, "The School Outside."

Conflicting Perspectives, Duration and the Residual Meaning of Objects

Modern time in the chapter is concentrated in one teaching day and an office meeting; Gangesha's ancient time consists of a brief period of philosophical debate. The third-person narration ranges through different consciousnesses: Lata's anxiety, Naira's memory of past error, Reva's exhausted questions, Rajo's economic argument, Meera and Harimohan's pedagogical exercise, and Sajid's checking of digital sources. Not all these voices reach the same conclusion. The shopkeeper claims goodwill but has not seen the original photograph. Lata feels the urgency of finding a

culprit; Naira insists upon limiting the accusation. Even after the correction, Lata's uncertainty persists.

Jatan pronounces "gavaya" as "gavaiya," bringing a small moment of humour into classical instruction. The shift of sound matters: the child is not a passive recipient of a lesson, but changes the word through his own auditory experience. The red image at the beginning and the shadows of two planks at the end frame the story. Naira refuses to treat a resemblance of external shadows as evidence. The closing three categories—resemblance observed, identity unverified, offence unproved—constitute an ethical accounting, not a successful search. The children's names appearing in their reading notebooks rather than on sheets of accusation offers symbolic relief; but removing a public suspicion does not diminish the genuine pain of a child's disappearance.

Achievement and limitation. The chapter's distinctive achievement is placing classical upamana against the unwarranted decisiveness of modern digital imagery without claiming that "every image is useless." The paperwork obstacle of two addresses socially extends the controversy about resemblance, yet Rajo's wage receipt and Lata's search notice are not interchangeable. One limitation is the excessively planned clarity with which three lines distinguishing types of evidence are set out in the class, the office and Naira's notebook. At times the characters' instant ethical acuity leaves too little room for ordinary psychological confusion. Nevertheless, Lata's wounded protest, Rajo's continuing wait for payment and the undecided school admission prevent the scene from becoming merely an administrative broadcast of a conclusion.

Chapter 36 — The School Outside

The Sinking Brick and the Unanswered Admission Question: A Story of Place

Jatan's notebook slips from a temporary platform of three bricks and falls into wet earth. This small event exposes the entire material logic of "the school outside": there are pages for education, a teacher and children, but no stable table, dry ground or safe route. The headteacher's letter from the previous chapter requests a proposal concerning the movement of a mobile class through the town, assistance with languages, safety and expenses. It is not a ruling on formal admission. Reva makes clear that deciding the children's everyday route without consulting them would reproduce the old exclusion in a new form. The chapter's centre shifts from the meaning of evidentiary terms to the practical infrastructure needed to transport knowledge and those who learn it.

Padma demands that her two roles—assisting in the class and explaining the language used in meetings—be recorded with separate hours and remuneration. Sanket brings a phone with a broken screen and an old speaker, but a girl for whom loud sound is difficult asks for marks on the board instead. Respecting her preference, they return the speaker to the bag. Technological assistance does not mean "make everyone listen through the same device"; it means adapting the medium to a user's preference and capacity. Although Padma makes the girl's gestures intelligible to others, she first checks their meaning with the girl herself. Acting as an intermediary for someone's voice does not confer ownership of that representation.

Rajainar: Not a Road on a Map, but an Obstacle to Unequal Bodies

At Rajainar, a leaning post, a loose railing and a question about water meet. Lalit explains that tightening the rope again does not amount to permanent repair. Madan's vehicle cannot be available at the same hour for both transporting patients and taking children regularly to class. Its hire charge may be reduced, but petrol and the driver's wages cannot simply be erased. Padma asks for words and shapes alongside colour codes: the same red or blue cannot be expected to signify the same thing to everyone with different kinds of visual understanding. These details break the abstract phrase "a safe route" into numerous interdependent demands of labour, time and sensory access.

The different objects in Jatan's, Reva's and Madan's hands—a notebook, a water vessel and a vehicle key—indicate different purposes for travelling the same route. Jatan imagines a new route while playing with a paper boat and water; Padma reminds him that there must also be a route for a child who cannot walk. This is one of the chapter's strongest images. A school map ceases to be a single arrow and becomes a shared construction shaped by the difficulties of different bodies and tasks. The paper boat recalls the preceding river narratives, but it is not actual transport infrastructure. Birsi's answer about looking for a "dry route" returns imagination to practical feasibility.

Lalit constructs a temporary barrier from bamboo, adds a written and pictorial warning and prepares separate receipts for materials and labour. Inspection of the railing does not establish that the well water is safe to drink; ownership of the surrounding land is another question. The chapter's outcome is therefore a temporary safety arrangement, not complete repair, proof of water quality or legal determination of a boundary. To merge these three unfinished matters into the statement "the school's problem was solved" would contradict the source.

Saraswati's Daughter, Pratima's Copy and Occupational Autonomy

Saraswati Thakur earns her living with comb and scissors; her daughter wants training in maintaining equipment wiring. A school employee readily assumes that the mother's occupation is the daughter's destiny. Saraswati does not disparage her own profession. She seeks her daughter's right to choose education according to her interests. Knowing that rearranging her uncertain night work hours may reduce her income, she decides to gather information about the training; the fees have not yet been raised. This is not a simple story of "liberation from an occupation," but a negotiation between the mother's labour rights and the daughter's different wishes for her future. Sanket does not allow the girl to handle powered equipment: learning electrical safety becomes the first real stage of training.

Pratima Rajvanshi brings an old family memory of a donation, a copy register and a map. The old boundary marks do not fully correspond to the present route. Rather than asserting an ultimate claim to ownership, she asks that the entrance path to the school not be enclosed until the original order and correct measurements are obtained. Her significant qualification is that, if the land proves to be public, permission must belong to the school as an institution, not to the donating family's whim. Thus the authority of private family memory itself becomes limited. The alternative possibility that some posts near Rajainar stand on private land is also preserved in Naira's notes.

The Multiple Levels of the Minutes: Permission, Privacy, Payment and Food

The minutes of the temporary school's committee become a distinctive narrative device. Padma has the limits of her interpreting and listening assistance recorded; she does not assume a right to publicise the private identities of children or families. Sanket rejects any obligation to display private faces as proof of the school's activity. Naira distinguishes three registers—lessons, repairs to the well and travel arrangements—and proposes limiting access and confidentiality according to the purpose of each. The papers concerning Mithun's search remain separate. Sarita's original page of twenty-seven names is not brought to this meeting. The archival ethics developed in earlier chapters have thus become practical rules of administration.

The headteacher's reply says that education on the temporary veranda should not be interrupted, but any new permission for a travelling class must be supported by a formal proposal setting out informed parental consent, a safe route and costs. A signature alone is insufficient: Padma demands consent understood in each family's language. The hours during

which Madan transports patients cannot be silently charged to the school account. At the end, the proposal for a mobile school is ready but authorisation is incomplete; no travel date has been set; formal enrolment remains a separate unresolved question. In this unfinished state the author controls the temptation to label a resolution of intent as an achieved result.

The shared meal prepared by Rukhsana forms a smaller but important connection with the initial "Kitchen of the Dead." Food is necessary, but the cook's time must be entered alongside the cost of grain. Urmila, already exhausted, draws water to help Rukhsana; she postpones the accounting dispute by saying "let everyone eat rice first," but does not cancel it. The value of Lalit's salvaged wood is entered as zero, whereas the labour needed to make a future permanent bench cannot be valued at zero. Through these two small economic distinctions, labour becomes not merely something the novel symbolically honours but an obligation arising in practice.

Narrative Time, Participatory Perspectives and Formal Limitations

The chapter occupies one modern day, from morning to night; it contains no independent ancient scene. Unlike the earlier Ahalya and Ekalavya episodes in Aranya Kanda, "The School Outside" locates its temporal structure entirely within collective decision-making in the present. The third-person narrator moves from scenes centred on objects to a meeting involving many characters. The girl's nonverbal and gestural participation, Reva's insistence concerning place, Madan's service hours, Saraswati's daughter's occupational interest, Pratima's limits on a family claim and Lalit's safety check all have their own needs and responsibilities. The "group" is not a crowd speaking with a single voice.

There are also grounds for criticism. Within one meeting, problems of schooling, labour, occupational choice, water, routes, accessibility, private information and food arise in an exceptionally orderly sequence. Some characters classify almost every objection correctly and without delay; the novelistic scene therefore occasionally resembles the minutes of a workshop. Yet Jatan's notebook falling from the bricks, the girl refusing the speaker, Madan's impossible timetable, the lack of fees and the darkness beyond the barrier retain the unmanageable aspects of living experience. The final decision—that no one will silently decide on behalf of the children without their understanding—is the beginning of a legal and ethical rule, not a completed achievement.

Vana Parva / Aranya Kanda: Overall Critical Assessment of Chapters 25–36

Redefining the Forest: Not Exile Alone, but a Society of Provisional Access

Across these twelve chapters of Vana Parva, the "forest" is not simply a geographical region of trees. Empty space on a train, a river landing, a temporary veranda, entry to a forest path, the market, the school gate, a wet roof and the lane beside Rajainar all become unstable boundaries of civic rights. In Chapter 25, Fakira's working hours collide with the office's hearing schedule. In Chapter 26, Guha's boat narrative clarifies the distinction between a modern boatman's wages and safety. The rewriting of Shabari in Chapter 27 places women's labour alongside food. The Hidimba episode in Chapter 28 opens the question of consent and access to forest routes. In Chapters 29–30, images circulating with rumours threaten to displace the reality of Mithun's disappearance. Chapters 31–32 examine the right to learn through the injured Ekalavya and Mrinal's desire to inquire. Chapters 33–36 place the making of texts, the editing of history, the meaning of words and the actual journey to school at the centre. This succession gives form to the differing conditions of entry facing people kept "outside" civic life. (Original Chapters 25–36.)

Measured against narrative causality, these twelve episodes are not equally successful. There is a clear continuity of ideas and material objects from the unsupported child-theft video to Sajid's visual lesson, thence to the practice of recognising errors of perception on the school board, on to damp books and an incomplete historical display, and finally to the two similar photographs. The practical question of Reva's children's temporary education returns at the next stage as a dispute about formal enrolment; the question "Where will the class be tomorrow?" in Chapter 35 leads directly to the plan for a travelling school in Chapter 36. But the temporal strands concerning Guha, Shabari, Hidimba and Ekalavya are not one unbroken chain of events in the same causal network. Their relations with the modern crisis are comparative, thematic and editorial. Without this distinction it would be wrong to claim that all the characters encounter one another or are literally connected.

Three Systems of Time and Different Instruments of Narration

The first temporality is the ordinary sequence of morning, afternoon and evening, during which attendance, journeys, meals, wages and preservation of papers occur. The second is the anticipated time of the office, contractor, school admission and repair: "the next meeting," "market day," "pending inquiry," "balance payable." This administratively

uncertain future sustains recurring narrative tension. The third is the imagined ancient time strand: the conversations of Guha, Shabari, Hidimba, Ahalya, Ekalavya, Vachaspati and Mrinal, Bhamati, Udayana and Gangesha. Each chapter does not give all three equal prominence. Chapter 29 is principally a contemporary investigation; Chapters 32–33 have extensive dual temporal structures; Chapter 36 is entirely located in a modern collective process. It is therefore inaccurate to say that Vana Parva proceeds throughout through identical two-time scenes.

Narrative duration also varies. The public time of rumour is rapid: an image is cropped, shared and turned into an accusation. Verification of a person's actual identity is slow. Temporary schooling continues each day while a formal order remains delayed. The time required to dry a wet page is governed by material conditions; answers in debate are left until the following day; the duration of Bhamati's lamp raises the question of bodily rest. These unequal durations have political meaning. The difference between a swift false declaration and delayed justice or payment becomes a structural rhythm, not merely a theme. Still, the recurring endings "question submitted in writing," "reply pending" and "next meeting" sometimes weaken dramatic culmination. This artistic limitation deserves recognition on the evidence.

The Government of Evidence: Four Different Errors and Four Different Corrections

The evidentiary problem in Vana Parva is not the scope of a single term. First come false or unsupported public allegations: the child-theft video and the image of Mohan circled in red. Checking their original contexts and sources alters the grounds of specific accusations; the search for the child continues separately. Second is the gap within a text: the incomplete line containing "Kritasara" prevents a settled meaning until an original or contextual evidence is found. Third is the historical record: a letter trimmed from a display board and anonymous women's labour omitted from an original register demand different evidence. Fourth are limits on philosophical inference: Udayana's debate questions the adequacy of adrishta and the necessity of a conscious cause; the gavaya analogy distinguishes grasping a word's meaning from identifying one particular person. What is "unseen" and what "looks the same" may appear opposites, yet they call for different procedures of proof. (Chapters 29–30, 33–35.)

Narratological and critical instruments help clarify these distinctions: reliability of the speaker, delimitation of the subject, the relation between reason and the proposition to be established, the limits of conclusions from missing evidence, and faithful restatement of an opposing position. But the modern application of these instruments must not be treated

either as a verbatim doctrine in ancient texts or as an event that literally occurred in the story. For example, the unproved claim that a particular crime follows from an image and a philosophical argument about the existence of God both concern "evidence," but their domains of proof, witnesses and standards of verification differ. Respecting those boundaries makes it possible to derive questions from the text rather than imposing philosophical analysis upon it.

Character Development and Evidence of Polyphony

Women's independent decisions constitute one of Vana Parva's central achievements, but its women are not "all the same symbol of resistance." Reva refuses to give a false address for her children; Chanda determines the risks and price of instruction; Meera refuses to call temporary attendance formal enrolment; Somri sets limits on the rights she may claim on behalf of fellow workers; Hema revises her first allegation; Nasima identifies the physical limit of letters removed in trimming; Rajo separates wage receipts from applications for assistance; Lata consents to correcting an accusation without abandoning her search for the missing child; Saraswati changes her work schedule in support of her daughter's interests; and Pratima subjects a possible family claim to rules of public use. These decisions do not have identical social consequences or identical risks. (Chapters 29–36.)

Jatan and Birsi's mistakes in writing, laughter, questions and drawings of routes carry the narration beyond summaries of adult dialogue. Jatan's reversed "ja" is not erased; Birsi retains the right for her "ba" to remain on paper; another girl chooses pictures rather than loud sound. The children's actual processes of learning thereby become sources of knowledge. Yet the strongest test is not simply whether a child is present; it is whether the child's question really changes procedure. Not playing the sound, adding an alternative route and asking permission to use an original drawing are concrete changes that make polyphony credible.

Ecology, Labour and the Meaning of Objects

Water is not scenery in this parva. Obstructed drainage, the capacity of a boat, the wet veranda, tin roofing, paper fibres, uncertain use of the well at Rajainar and the changing routes through flooded lanes are causal environmental conditions of the plot. But "water" is not one interchangeable metaphor for every issue: sometimes it is a flowing current, sometimes dampness destroying an archive, sometimes a question of safe drinking water, sometimes an obstacle to travel. These material differences matter to ecological narratology. No description of atmosphere alone establishes a definite offence of administrative negligence in a water-related problem. Risk reports, measurements, repair receipts and actual liability require separate inquiry.

The meaning of labour varies across cooking, copying, manufacturing paper, roofing, boat work, school materials, translation, communication through gestures and transport. Receiving half of one's wages with the remainder owed in grain, recording only a payment date, fixing an instructional fee in advance, and valuing salvaged wood at zero while recognising the separate labour of making a future bench are all numerically precise distinctions with literary significance. The author does not merely praise labour as "dignified": he makes it a contested question of receipts, time and remuneration. But the procedure is also repetitive. The prompt entry of written payment conditions for almost every newly introduced worker may bring a mechanical discipline into the story's natural flow.

Critical Counterarguments and Vana Parva's Actual Conclusion

The parva's principal achievement is not only confronting official categories with the lives of those excluded by them. It also shows which questions remain after an error in classification has been corrected. An erroneous accusation is revised, but the missing child is not found. Training begins, but enrolment does not. Wages are entered on a line, but full payment is not made. A warning is attached to the historical display, but the final list of names is not established. An identity in a photograph remains unverified, and the search continues. The children may study on the outdoor veranda, while a travelling class is still only a proposal. This succession of incomplete outcomes lends the narrative its ethical credibility.

There are also two substantial formal limitations. First, the characters repeatedly express unusually precise theoretical distinctions in the midst of complex problems; the class, generational and emotional differences of local speech are at times less audible. Second, the recurring construction—event, interpretation, register, incomplete outcome—makes the rhythm predictable. An impartial criticism cannot dismiss these shortcomings by calling them simply virtues of an "educational work." Yet Lata's bitterness, Reva's fatigue, Somri's fear of losing her job, the children's restlessness and the unpaid wages are countervailing evidence of life that prevents the intellectual programme from becoming entirely frictionless.

Vana Parva ends not in a single scene of victory but in a small movement towards establishing shared procedures of decision-making. In the novel's opening "Kitchen of the Dead," a death notice had been used as a documentary attack upon a living person. At the end of these twelve forest chapters, a child's small voice begins to remake the conditions under which documents can exercise authority: no one may decide for the children without their understanding. The relationship with the Mahabharata's Vana Parva and the Ramayana's Aranya Kanda lies in the

narrative questions of journey, exclusion, work and knowledge. To treat the modern characters as exact counterparts of ancient characters in caste or verifiable history would distort the text's purpose.

Chapter 37 — The Cook's Name

An Opening Among Wet Bricks: The Space for Food Comes into Conflict with the Space for Education

The chapter opens with Rukhsana arriving on the school veranda after the rain. Her first act is not to light the stove but to move its wet brickwork aside. The need to protect the children's notebooks from smoke and mud makes her, not merely a kitchen "helper," but the person taking a technical decision about space. Meera brings the idea of providing meals for two days, but Rukhsana immediately asks three questions: how many children, who will cook, and who will pay? The opening scene makes visible the stages of labour concealed between "grain donated" and "food prepared." Classes continue on the school's outer veranda, although final permission for the itinerant school and formal enrolment are still pending. This incompleteness places the immediate arrangements for food alongside the longer uncertainty surrounding the right to education.

Reva considers helping for an hour on the condition that her son Jatan's studies are not interrupted. An official assumes that the "mothers of the household" are available without payment; Rukhsana exposes this unequal valuation by citing the paid time required to prepare the official's own register. The force of the argument lies not in a sentimental glorification of women but in a comparison of working conditions. Reva is capable of deciding for herself: she may serve voluntarily for an hour without being designated a permanent attendant the following day. Safeguarding both the freedom to serve and the freedom to refuse service is the chapter's fundamental ethical boundary. In Rukhsana's view, treating "voluntary service" as an inexhaustible source of unpaid public labour amounts to constructing an undeclared contract in the name of charity.

A Sheet with Three Headings: Making the Division of Labour Visible to the Reader

Before the annual Shared Kitchen and Wages Day, three headings are written on a board: ingredients; roasting and preparation; and the labour of cooking and serving. The narrative turns an ordinary list into an operative structure: the outcome of negotiations changes according to where each newcomer's work belongs on it. Raghu Sahu distinguishes the firing of his roasting oven, roasting time, and transport charges from ownership of the raw grain. Chandrika Rai raises the question of ingredients, lost business while her shop is closed, and the legitimacy of profit within the price of prepared food. Nasim Idrisi records the number of sewn cloth bags, sewing time, and instructions for their use, but refuses

the request to stitch children's names onto bags displayed in public. This proliferation of papers is not authorial decoration: each trade has a different unit of documentation.

In Durga Gangai's business selling a makhana mixture, a first consignment at a low price is a way to reach prospective customers. Calling it a free donation would make the small trader's right to market her goods disappear. The historical meaning of "Gahuma," found in an old page of hers, remains unclear. When Naira asks permission to photograph it, Durga first wants an account of the sale. This episode resists the narrative's own documentary enthusiasm: a researcher's curiosity does not automatically outrank a small business's immediate economic needs. An old name has been found, but its definite association with a place or river has not been demonstrated. Such negative limits enhance the credibility of historical inquiry.

Farida Qureshi brings covered vessels, a weighing scale, and written supply rates. When her family's meat-selling business prompts suggestions of exclusion, she demands the same standards of measurement, hygiene, and inspection for everyone. An earlier health-inspection receipt is produced, but it is not declared a final answer to every possible allegation. Farida keeps the option of requesting an inspection open. At this point the plot resists occupational prejudice without manufacturing an instantly harmonious social ending. The exchanges among Raghu, Chandrika, Nasim, Durga, and Farida disclose five distinct commercial interests; a single collective "community" voice is not imposed upon them.

Ballava's Royal Kitchen: The Unequal Logic of Concealed Identity and Public Credit

In ancient Viratanagara, Bhima enters the royal kitchen under the name Ballava. His physical strength and knowledge of cooking are treated separately: when the measure of spices is in question, he learns from a woman experienced in pounding grain. The figure of the "strong cook" in name alone is thus enlarged by the technical ability to listen. Ballava's name appears in the royal ledger, while those who sort grain, dry firewood, and tend the flames are subsumed under "kitchen people." Ballava presses the question: if the food runs short, upon whom will blame fall, and if it succeeds, who will receive credit? His decision does not immediately establish labour justice in the royal establishment; it begins the making of separate entries for the actual tasks performed.

Intertextuality requires particular care here. Ballava's assumed name is necessary to protect himself and his family during their concealed exile; Rukhsana's modern name is needed for public recognition of her right to payment. "Name" does not mean the same thing in both cases. To replace

Ballava's concealed identity with a universal rule requiring everyone's names to be published would erase the danger to his life. Nor do Rukhsana, Nasim, and Reva demand publication of every identity everywhere: a child's school name belongs in a private list, not on a bag; one hour of voluntary service must not be turned into permanent employment. The novel constructs the right to a name as a contextual arrangement governing when, how, and for what purpose a name is recorded. The Viratanagara scene is the novel's reconstruction, not a literal historical record of events in the Mahabharata.

The Measure of Grain, the Testing of Water, and the Time of Working Bodies

By midday the supply of rice and shortage of fuel alter the meal plan. Rukhsana turns the proposed two-day arrangement into a definite meal on the first day and a conditional arrangement for the second. This is a real change of decision within the story; it would be wrong to conclude that meals have been prepared for two days. Instead of using untested water from Rajainar, Urmila carries pitchers from another usable supply point. The time spent transporting this water is recorded separately from the earlier outstanding payment for carrying hospital laundry. These three relationships involve distinct risks: lack of raw materials, the health danger of untested water, and the disappearance of a worker's unpaid work on another day into the current task.

Blisters on Rukhsana's hands, Chandrika's closed shop, and the distribution of rest time make time more than a number on a clock: they give it the form of bodily capacity and opportunity cost. Chandrika takes on half an hour of serving, but that help is a temporary adjustment for the present day. The older donor who wants his name placed at the top is not deprived of the weight of his contribution; the paper specifies "rice," clarifying what he is to be credited for. Neither contempt for donation nor appropriation of labour: this third possibility becomes the story's ethical result. The food is distributed successfully and the children eat, but formal enrolment and the budget for the following day remain unresolved.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, and Evaluation

The modern story runs from the wet stove in the morning to the copy of accounts made in the evening; the ancient story is interwoven with Ballava's experiences on his first day and at night. What joins the two temporal strands is not a shared date but the visible resemblance of the work and the social function of a name. The third-person narrative stays chiefly close to Rukhsana's experience, while giving Raghu, Chandrika, Durga, Farida, Reva, and Ballava questions arising from distinct interests. The children's joking question, "Whose pinch is this?", turns the idea of

measurement into a scene rather than a speech. The ordinary sensation of salt in rice, a cloth bag, wet bricks, and a warm water pitcher provide the material ground of the narrative language.

From a narratological perspective, the premise “grain has been received as a donation” does not, by itself, yield the conclusion “a free meal service is assured.” Fuel, water, labour, vessels, time, and continuing payment are all conditions requiring examination. The availability of raw materials is not a sufficient cause of a complete service. The narrative’s achievement lies in making documentary differentiation change the actual programme. Its limitation is that representatives of several occupations enter in orderly succession with highly alert, evidence-based arguments; the arrangement can occasionally resemble a systematic display of an occupational register. The bodily fatigue of Rukhsana, Chandrika’s question of profit, and Durga’s immediate commercial concerns bring the friction of life into this planned form. At the close, Rukhsana still desires a future shop of her own and the chance, sometimes, to be a spectator; the shop has not opened, and the testing of Rajainar’s water remains incomplete.

Chapter 38 — Brihannala’s Class

From the Kitchen to the Spectators’ Seats: Changing a Character’s Role

On the following morning, Rukhsana dries receipts at home, drinks tea instead of cooking, and decides to watch Ruhani’s dance class. The immediate result of the preceding chapter’s labour register is not that all her arrears have been paid; it is that she can choose how to use one day of her own time. Meera begins to ask her about possible kitchen work, but Ruhani asks that her name be entered among the spectators. Being a spectator here is not idleness; it is an alternative to society’s assigning the same person a perpetual duty to serve. When Jatan becomes anxious after stepping on his notebook, Ruhani reduces the pressure of an “examination.” The movement of a child’s body becomes material for learning, not a mark of failure.

The scene repeatedly describes rhythm, foot placement, strips laid on the ground, arm movements, and applause from spectators. At first this may look like a colourful interlude of dance, but decisions turn on who receives how much teaching time, under which name, and on what terms. Rukhsana’s applause returns near the chapter’s end, when Jatan lifts the strip and marks his own position again. This is a small character arc from initial hesitation to self-correction; nothing shows Jatan winning a great public stage.

Arjuna as Brihannala and Ruhani's Self-Identification: An Unequal Intertext

In King Virata's palace, Arjuna, under the name Brihannala, teaches Princess Uttara music and dance because of his vow of concealment and his need for safety. He does not seize Uttara's hand to correct her physical movement by force, but guides her through observation and rhythm. When Uttara asks, "Whose people are you outside?", he accepts the limits placed on his answer by his vow rather than devising an entirely new lie. An incomplete answer does not wholly destroy the ethical trust of teaching within the classroom, but the pupil's dissatisfaction remains. In this ancient temporal strand, disguise, silence, and authority are complex matters.

In Videhapur, a poster printed for grant funding bears the heading "Brihannala's Dance: Special Hijra Performance." The controversy over this phrase constitutes one of the original novel's clearest tests of intertextuality. Ruhani explains that Arjuna's disguise during concealment cannot be equated with her own social and personal identity. The popularity of an old story does not confer permission to treat a contemporary person's life as a "costume" or an object of spectacle. Ruhani does not immediately tear down the board and humiliate the official; she demands the chain of authorisation for its wording and a written amendment. Padma preserves evidence of the poster's heading, not images of the children. In this way the narrative interrogates the mythological comparison itself: this is not the "repetition of myth," but a critique of the improper use of a mythical resemblance.

The ancient Brihannala risks breaking the condition of concealed exile if his identity is revealed; Ruhani risks having an identity she has accepted for herself turned by an institution into saleable publicity. These are socially different predicaments. Treating them as "identical suffering" would efface the story's ethical distinction. Ruhani herself repeats the difference to the children; when Birsi asks, "Whom shall I be in the play?", the answer is, "First we must read the story." Respect for a character's independent experience is an accomplishment of the intertextual technique. Yet the distinction is stated twice in unusually explicit terms; to a critical reader the repetition may appear both a meaningful warning and, in part, an expansion into didactic explanation.

Dulari's Ration Slip: A Signature That Does Not Establish Consent

Separate from Ruhani's class, Dulari Rajwar arrives after hearing an announcement about a ration-relief camp. The final line of a collective consent form makes the relief received conditional on its adjustment against a personal debt. The official's insistence that "everyone signs" is no

evidence of individual consent. Dulari reads the paper, asks Padma to explain the line, refuses to sign, and takes a written copy. A subsequent official note records that she has not relinquished her right to receive rations and that the debt is a separate matter for decision. Nevertheless, no relief is distributed that day. The story consistently distinguishes a "contract refused" from a "right actually received."

Dulari turns back and tells the official that the household of four has enough grain left for three days. The official agrees to add this circumstance to the application, but does not promise distribution. Narrative time comes almost to a standstill for a few moments: the danger of receiving no assistance becomes visible in numbers. Dulari's calculation is not simply an emblem of pathos; it attempts to put the quantity of immediate hunger into the record. The language of rights here connects with Rukhsana's food accounts, but organising communal meals and expecting the state to distribute rations are different administrative processes and should not be conflated.

The Cost of the Class, the Choice of One's Occupation, and the Conditions of Training

Bhola Yadav wants the earlier credit for milk supplied to be kept separate from charges for the current class; the payment date is recorded, though no money has reached his hands. Phoolmati Tiyar refuses permission to turn her fishing net into a children's decoration because its knots could entangle a body; she provides a separate sample and rate for a shade net. In both episodes craft expertise is not merely a slogan about "the people's handicrafts"; it is the authority to determine an appropriate use for a material object. The earlier accounts for Phoolmati's jointly owned fishing net remain incomplete, and the wages for the new class are recorded separately.

Farid Chik tries to make room in his schedule for rhythmic instruction at school alongside the family's meat-selling trade. Not everyone in his family agrees. Rather than inventing a dramatic scene of open opposition, he makes a timetable for himself. Ruhani does not regard "every rhythm that falls behind" as wrong; she proposes altering the beat to suit the child's gait. In the ancient account of Uttara's lessons, too, the question arises of teaching a female attendant's daughter. She is not immediately admitted; a request is made for additional teaching time and a teacher's responsibility. In both temporal strands, educational justice is bound to the actual costs of an hour, an instructor, and safe materials.

In the evening Meera reads a proposal to enter Nasim's sewing, Parvati's yarn, and Pavitra's knotting as separate charges. Those artisans have not yet attended the class, so it would be wrong to consider their rates or

consent approved in this chapter. The poster is renamed "Shared Rhythm and Dance Class," but separate consent from families and children is required for publishing images, voices, and names. The division between a public expenditure statement and private consent forms is an administrative improvement; regular funds, permission for a performance venue, and formal enrolment for the itinerant school remain pending.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, and the Limits of Achievement

The story takes place between the following morning and evening during the hours of the class, interspersed with the first and second days of practice in Viratanagara. The lively pace of the modern gathering, the slow practice of the ancient royal room, and the pause while Dulari reads the document produce different durations. The third-person narrator gives priority to Ruhani's decisions, but does not dissolve the official's limits of authority, Dulari's anxiety over food, Farid's occupational struggle, and Rukhsana's wish for rest into a single voice. Padma's photograph of the poster is evidence only of its wording, not an image of a child: an elegant example of delimiting the subject of evidence.

The chapter's foremost literary achievement is that invoking the Mahabharata character "Brihannala" does not automatically validate the social identity of the modern Ruhani. The character herself objects to an overextended mythological analogy. A limitation is that disputes about private consent, receipts, payment, occupational rights, and the standing of particular crafts are almost invariably answered by immediately drawing up a separate sheet; the action can sometimes resemble a workshop on administrative reform. But the immediacy of Dulari's hunger, Rukhsana's blisters, and Farid's family disagreements preserve the socially difficult and unresolved elements.

Chapter 39 — The Weaver's Dues

The Sound of the Warp and the Many Hands in a Single Object

The chapter opens in Parvati Tanti's courtyard with a morning loom, damp yarn, and a shuttle scraping against its course. This sound is not merely atmosphere; it is a direct route to the worker's knowledge of the material's condition. Parvati corrects a defect with a drop of oil and worries about cost before displaying the fabric at school. A length of cloth for a pagri incorporates her weaving and the edging knotted by Pavitra Patwa. To someone looking at it, it is "one cloth"; in the time of labour and debt, however, it belongs to two households. Without this initial distinction, the economic dispute running through the chapter cannot be

understood. Pavitra explains the value of time saved by a knot; saving labour does not mean erasing the line recording its wages.

Yusuf Ansari's bag of loom parts and his son's proposal to sell fabric through a telephone introduce new instruments of the market. In reply to Yusuf, Parvati identifies weaving and digital selling as separate skills. Yusuf's son would prefer a different course of training in electronics, while the demands of household repairs remain. During the day Yusuf tells his son over the telephone not to abandon his training and return immediately. This conversation registers a small change, not the end of every household problem. Parvati's mother-in-law remembers the old practice of entering the price under a man's name. The older woman's desire for beauty is also alive: she lays a coloured border over her shoulder and looks in a mirror. Intergenerational memory is not reduced to economic data alone.

The "Complete Package" Account: The Convenience of a Grant and the Exclusion of Labour

The school's rate sheet groups yarn, weaving, dyeing, edging, sewing, and decoration under a single "dance-costume complete package." The official's position is one of institutional convenience: a single bill simplifies grant procedures. Parvati and Pavitra reply that if payment is made under one name on one line, what happens to the amounts due to separate producers? Sonmati Turi asks for rent for her frame; Ruchi Dharikar wants to prevent unauthorised external copying of her coloured-strip design. This is more than a moral appeal to "give everyone credit": whose yarn, whose design, whose equipment, whose right to authorise copies, and whose payment are separate subjects of economic agreement.

The decisive change for criticism occurs in the nineteenth and twentieth passages. The official's single entry is divided into five: Yusuf's yarn, Parvati's weaving, Pavitra's knotting, Sonmati's frame rental, and use of Ruchi's sample. Meera raises a real concern about delays in budget approval. Parvati agrees only to a small advance commission for making a sample—its duration and payment must first be specified in writing; an order for a complete length of cloth is a separate matter. To read this agreement as "all five producers' rates have been approved" would mislead: not every price is accepted on the final sheet. The evidence of reform is a new rate sheet, not a receipt proving full payment.

Children's Safety, Limited Orders, and Judgment Concerning the Use of Cloth

On seeing Kamlesh Khatik's red band, someone initially suspects a connection with a disputed consignment. His purchase bill establishes the

number of items but not whether the band is suitable for a child's body or whether the order specifies its measurement; these require different checks. When Farid lays the band across an arm it leaves a harsh mark, and Ruhani recognises the safety risk to a child's waist. The appearance of a market shopkeeper's name on an old hospital weighing slip does not prove that the two articles belong to the same illicit consignment. Naira explicitly asks that the order's measurements, the item's intended use, and the receipt date be investigated separately. Kamlesh's community identity is not used as grounds for an accusation; testing the fitness of his product is still outstanding.

This episode matters for the story's examination of evidence. Similarity of red colour, similarity of a commercial name, and belonging to the same material supply chain are three different propositions to be established. To derive the third from the first two visual indicators would be an underdetermined inference. This is not a tale of identifying a culprit quickly but of preventing an allegation unsupported by evidence. Naira herself asks permission to take a photograph. Kamlesh refuses; she accepts the refusal. After the unauthorised digital publication in Chapter 20, this is evidence of a change in her behaviour. It does not, however, warrant the general claim that Naira always makes the right decision.

A parent pulls at Ruchi's strip to test its security and learns the distinction between looking attractive and being safe against the body. Ruhani wants the fabric not to catch during the children's dance; Pavitra records the dimensions of the knots; Sonmati's frame allows the colours to be examined without wrapping the material around a body. Protecting the samples from a leaking roof also registers an environmental obstacle: the structural safety of the place matters just as much as aesthetic design. The threat of water is not external to the Virata Parva story of "craft"; it becomes a condition of the durability of materials.

Producers' Autonomy, Debt, and a Visual Interval of Rest

Sonmati asks for separate authorisation for an outside trade exhibition and use at the school. Ruchi sews an identifying mark onto her sample. The narrative is not declaring a complete judicial doctrine of modern intellectual-property law; it insists upon the difference between permission to copy and permission to display. Rather than conceal a defective length of cloth, Yusuf agrees to mark the fault on the sample. This scene of commercial transparency is not compulsory praise of the "craftsperson's image"; it accepts the risks of quality control. Dues to an earlier trader and the son's training fees remain distinct problems in the household accounts. The prospect of an advance does not automatically settle earlier debt.

Rukhsana becomes a spectator of colours again. Birsi calls the blue yarn "cool like the sky" and the green border "warm like the field"; the girl creates the meaning of colours from her own sensations. Colours are released from a fixed symbolic destiny imposed by caste, religion, or social identity. Such sensory passages are especially successful as literature, because the child's aesthetic experience appears outside the arithmetic of wages. In the final conversation between Parvati and Pavitra, separate prices do not signify separate affection: the difference is between labour that has been joined together and names that have been erased. A splinter of yarn in a finger and a packet of jaggery brought by a friend join the contemporary hardship of work with mutual care, without idealising either.

Narrative Technique, Evidence, and the Critical Counterargument

The chapter's modern temporal course runs from the morning loom to the new rate sheet in the evening. There is no independent ancient Viratanagara scene here, although the parva's name recalls the Mahabharata's setting of disguised identity. This distinction matters: being located in a mythological parva does not require every chapter to contain a separate scene in two temporal worlds. The third-person narrative begins close to Parvati's technical hearing and expands into the school's dispute among several suppliers. The beat of the loom, moisture in the yarn, knots, the touch of colours, and drops from the roof form a chain of narrative objects. The question of "names" has now become a layered matter of consolidated labour cost, design permission, and safety inspection.

A major achievement is that putting prices under separate headings produces a real budgetary conflict within the story: everyone does not readily agree once wages are requested. A major limitation is that, on the same day, several new representatives of different crafts arrive in succession with lucid ethical arguments; occupational diversity risks becoming a visual exhibition. The characters' disputes often reach sensible resolutions quickly, whereas actual social and economic conflicts can last a long time. Yet Meera's budget worries, Kamlesh's unsafe material, Yusuf's family debts, and the unusable roof prevent the process from becoming a fantasy of fully accomplished reform. The final thread of the fabric has not been cut: a causal strand has been prepared for the following chapter's washing, registers, and older outstanding hospital payments.

Chapter 40 — The Laundry Register

Mud at the Ghat and Urmila's Two Ledgers: The Beginning of Recorded Time

The chapter opens at the ghat in the morning with Urmila checking the washing slab, stacking loads, and counting damp pages. Hospital records are kept separately in an oiled cover, while her own wage papers are in another bundle. The significance of this material separation becomes clear later: private details connected with a patient's treatment and the actual working hours of a labourer are not the same kind of public evidence. Urmila has heard the preceding chapter's discussion of separate rates for Parvati and Pavitra, but first clarifies that washing the school's dance costumes and the hospital's outstanding laundry payment are different matters. Narrative continuity does not mean combining every ledger; it means testing a concept of work in another field.

At the ghat of Barki Pokhari, the bathing steps, washing slab, and place where handcarts unload serve distinct purposes. A warehouse grille and stacked boxes have obstructed passage. Amid Renu's proposals for measurements and flags, Urmila insists that the footpath and access to the slab must be secured first. A celebration of Cleaning Day, photographs of that celebration, and the ghat's daily use are not synonymous. While taking clean sheets for her mother's treatment, Champa asserts her right not to have her face and the sheets included together in a photograph. Being present in a public place does not itself amount to consent to disclose medical privacy.

Nets, Bricks, Winnowing Trays, and Practical Knowledge of Objects

Saroj Kharkaut brings samples of an old worn-out net and one woven with new thread. Behind the warning not to mistake the knots of a fishing net for rubbish and throw them away during cleaning lies a question of repair wages. The rate of the new net's thread was entered; the hours needed for knotting had initially been left blank. Urmila's intervention gets the time recorded immediately, but the division of shares is not finally determined in the absence of those who made the net. Gita Kori raises the issue of incomplete payment for cloth of hers that crossed the border. A grey colour resembling that of a hospital sheet does not prove that both came from the same supply consignment. Experience of objects in different trades provides practical knowledge, but similarity of experience is not conclusive evidence of a connected chain.

Noorjahan, a brick seller, waters her donkey and tests the slippery conditions at the ghat. Unloading heavy bricks would put the broken edge at risk. Madhuri Dangi's group wants the labour of winnowing grain

recorded separately from the cost of the grain itself. The communal cleaning of the ghat shows the interdependence of bodies, animals, drainage, carts, and food. Environmental narratology here is not simply a reading of water imagery: it examines the causal limits imposed by a broken slab, the direction of drainage, knots in nets, and an animal's burden. Whether Noorjahan's cart can arrive, where a net is pegged, and who winnowed the grain are small details that become distinct measures of safety in social life.

Seven Forty-Five, Eight Twenty, and Nine O'Clock: Testing the Evidence of a Reversed Chronology

The decisive event in the chapter is a discrepancy among three registers. Urmila's ghat register says fourteen bundles were collected at 8:20; the hospital supply-room copy records them as "received" at 7:45; the gate register records the handcart's entry after nine o'clock. In the first two records, the time of "receipt" precedes the actual collection. There is, however, no single explanation: an advance-opened slip, a previous consignment, an incorrect entry, or some other procedure remain possibilities to be investigated. Aniruddha orders an examination of the correction to the supply sheet without immediately declaring anyone guilty. The driver's signature in the third, gate register is unclear; whether it was Urmila's cart therefore requires independent verification.

In the discipline of narrative evidence, the subject is the hospital-register entry for a specified date; the proposition to be established is the actual time at which the laundry was received; the offered ground is the printed "received" time; and the possible qualifying conditions include a practice of opening slips in advance, an exchange of consignments, or the description of a different article. Urmila's direct reading of the clock is evidence of her collection time, but she did not directly witness who wrote the hospital entry. The verbal testimony of the hospital copy can be assessed once the relevant procedure is understood. A cart leaving the ghat at 8:20 cannot ordinarily arrive at the hospital with those same bundles at 7:45. Yet the impossibility of the sequence as presented does not itself license the conclusion that forgery must have occurred. This is among the novel's most subtle investigations of evidence.

Thirty to thirty-five minutes have been deducted from Urmila's wage entry, and she asks by what process the deduction was made. The social stakes of the evidence are now clear: the chronology of a report is not merely an intellectual puzzle but the basis for a worker's actual pay. Another sheet records time spent counting bags, separately washing particular fabrics on the slab, waiting for specially designated laundry, and loading it onto the cart, whereas the payment document lists only a

washing fee per bundle. The event's achievement lies in beginning to change the record's language, not in any result showing that all arrears have been paid.

Patient Privacy and the Limits of the Researcher's Gaze

When Naira asks for Urmila's register, Urmila first asks her purpose: a patient's name, a worker's name, and the date on a laundry bag are different kinds of information. Aniruddha conceals patient identities in the hospital's certified copy. Champa may ask whether the reversed times affected treatment; the available public copy mentions a request for an additional sheet, but does not establish who needed it or when it was provided. It would be improper to turn incomplete records into a definite accusation of medical harm. Patient safety and the examination of wages are not antagonists: the necessary evidence about times can be disclosed while private treatment records remain protected.

Sanket asks permission before taking a photograph. Urmila stipulates that it must not include Champa or identifying marks on patients' laundry bags, and that time spent stopping work for photographs must itself be accounted for. These terms exemplify the ethical production of visual evidence. The beauty of a photograph of "working hands" is one thing; identifiable objects involved in the work and the rights of the people affected are another. The conflict between a photographer's freedom and the photographed worker's claim upon her own time cannot be resolved merely by "not showing the face." Control over information is decided in the narrative through negotiation with each person.

Three Decisions and the Causal Link to the Next Chapter on the Carpenter

After the meeting, three decisions are put in writing: record separately the time of collection at the ghat and actual entry at the hospital; count the worker's waiting time and specialised sorting labour separately; and require permission for publishing photographs or private laundry records. No new wage rate is fixed. Responsibility for a temporary cart route at the ghat is recorded, but no heavy permanent repairs begin without an inspection. Two hours of Urmila's wages are still outstanding, and the inquiry into the reversed times is preliminary. Without recognising these specified incompletions, to say that "register reform has achieved justice" would diminish the essay's ethical question.

Just before the final passage Urmila shows Naira a copy of an old repair bill. A wooden unloading ramp used to load laundry between the ghat and the hospital is described as "newly built," yet the space for carpenter Lalit's signature is blank. This copy does not yet establish who approved the

payment, who made the wooden ramp, or whether the error constitutes a crime. But it raises a concrete question for investigation: was the object actually made or merely entered on paper, and whose signature was required? This is a legitimate causal transition to the next chapter, "The Carpenter's Signature"; one cannot invent the following chapter's outcome by extrapolating from its title.

Time, Space, Language, and Literary Judgment

The day of the plot stretches from the morning's washing slab to the evening's safeguarding of records. When the figures "7:45" and "8:20" appear, narrative time itself becomes the subject of inquiry: the order in which the narrator presents events cannot be substituted for the actual sequence in which the cloth physically moved. The timelines of three records oblige the reader to work at arranging the evidence. Focalisation stays close to Urmila's direct experience of work, while Naira examines possible meanings of the papers, Aniruddha explains the limits of institutional correction, Champa voices concern over privacy, and Noorjahan, Saroj, and Madhuri attend to the practical safety of objects. These positions prevent the records from becoming a simplistic opposition between "official lies" and "people's truth."

The chapter's achievement is to connect the measurement of chronological inconsistency with wage deductions, privacy, and physical transportation. The Cleaning Day scene maintains a distinction between festival and service; no one is turned into a deity. As a limitation, the meeting's orderly compilation of three rules can read like a policy memorandum, risking a sequence of written decisions in place of changing narrative tension. But the two contradictory hospital times, the indistinct signature, and the incomplete ledger kept in Urmila's hands sustain the reader's question about what follows.

Virata Parva / Aranya Kanda: A Combined Critical Study of Chapters 37–40

From the Separation of Labour to the Continuity of Rights

The order of these four chapters is not merely a transition from one object to another. First, raw ingredients, preparation, cooking, and serving are distinguished; then the dance instructor, children's consent, publication of images, and materials; next come the five charges for yarn, weaving, edging, frames, and samples; finally, the collection, arrival, waiting, and washing of laundry from the ghat to the hospital. Each distinction produces new information, but the social purpose of each is not identical. Recognition of workers, children's safety, permission to use commercial

designs, and the investigation of wages belong to four different orders of rights. Accordingly, even where the register method is a common linguistic device across the four chapters, the structure of its consequences differs.

The community receives a meal in the first chapter; a shared dance class takes place in the second; a separate rate sheet is drafted in the third; and the fourth brings an order to examine the hospital register. To treat these as four equal steps of progress would be an error. A meal has an immediate bodily effect, the class takes place provisionally, the rate sheet offers a framework for an economic promise, and the order to investigate begins an inquiry into truth. The distance between creating a document and implementing a right must be measured differently in all four instances. An important capacity of the narrative is not to erase that distance but to stop where the available evidence stops.

The Name of the Mahabharata's Virata Parva: Disguised Identity and Modern Visibility

The ancient scenes with Ballava-Bhima in Chapter 37 and Brihannala-Arjuna in Chapter 38 offer two kinds of condition: the protective necessity of not revealing one's true name, and the ethical necessity of publicly recognising the names of other workers. In the modern story, Rukhsana's wages should be publicly acknowledged but a child's personalised name need not be written on a bag. Ruhani's self-identification must be accepted, but it must not be made into a commercial imitation of Brihannala's disguise. Kamlesh's bill may be verified, but he should not be photographed without consent. Urmila's evidence concerning work time should be examined without disclosing patients' names. Thus the "Virata" form of the narrative becomes a complex field of the right to be visible or invisible, not simply the staging of an ancient story. Although Chapters 39 and 40 contain no separate ancient scenes, they continue to expand this field of problems narratively.

Evidence and Narrative Statement in the Plot: Qualifying Conditions, Delimitation, and Conflicting Copies

Four particular unproved inferences are identified: receipt of donated rice equals certainty of meals for two days; use of a familiar mythological word on a poster equals a valid name for Ruhani's identity; a red strip and the same shopkeeper's name equal the hospital's criminal consignment; and the supply room's recorded "received" time equals the laundry's actual physical arrival. In each case the proposition to be established must be separately specified, the offered ground limited, and possible qualifying conditions considered. This critical method does not require declaring the

novel's documentary statements automatically true or automatically false. The witness's identity, the purpose of the paper, the temporal delimitation, valid consent, and material testing are different levels. The vocabulary of the foundational disciplines of narratology functions here as a critical instrument, not as a literal classical equivalent of modern school and hospital administration.

Polyphony, Bodies, and Water: Formal Limits of Representation

Rukhsana, Ruhani, Parvati, and Urmila are not merely exemplary embodiments of human effort. Rukhsana's desire for rest is itself a right to recreation; Ruhani's teaching process involves control over her identity; Parvati has commercial prices and an aesthetic sensibility; Urmila's insistence on dates and times is a practical question of pay. Each woman possesses distinct emotional, professional, and decisional dimensions. The comments of children Jatan and Birsi on steps, rhythm, and colour reveal emotional responses and different speeds of learning. Nor do male characters constitute a single opposition: Raghu asks for payment for labour, Bhola for outstanding credit, Yusuf fears change in his family, and Kamlesh rejects an accusation made without evidence. Such diversity must be considered through the independent voices that give it textual presence; nevertheless, the mere appearance of different occupations does not prove complete polyphony.

Across the four chapters many characters speak systematically in the language of receipts, textual passages, timetables, and written conditions. This clarifies social complexity, but everyday speech's unfinished quality, obscure conflicts of interest, administrative inertia, and unexpected mistakes are less often seen. The density of poetic images—wet stoves, blisters, Birsi's colours, the loom's sound, mud at the ghat—balances this argumentative style. Water here is not solely an omen of catastrophe: it is an everyday material condition of stove safety, cloth quality, the school roof, access to the ghat, and hospital transport. It is therefore appropriate to ground a "parallel" perspective on social history in modern workers' names and ledgers of what they are owed, not to manufacture an unverified history of past glory.

Interim Conclusion and Further Questions for Research

The opening of the Virata Parva turns a campaign to "write down the names of work" into the question "Which rights actually change once names are written down?" Archival accountability is the shared premise of the four chapters, but the pace of solutions differs. Food is served for one day, the identity of the class is corrected, sample rates are separated, and an investigation of reversed times begins. Facts remaining unresolved include the budget for the second day, permission for a performance venue,

approval of the full charges, the hospital's actual receipt time, and outstanding wages. The outcome of the unloading-ramp dispute can be described only after reading the actual text of Chapter 41, "The Carpenter's Signature." This interim assessment does not treat a prediction about that next chapter as an event that has already happened.

Chapter 41 — The Carpenter's Signature

The Wording of a Bill and an Object Made of Wood: The Plot's First Contradiction

The chapter opens with a damp paper in Lalit Vishwakarma's morning workshop. It is a repair bill for the wooden unloading ramp used to move laundry between the hospital and the ghat; in the blank approval box a red mark orders, "Sign here." The narrator describes Lalit's plane, saw, drying timber, and an old injury to his hand. These are not embellishments: from the first scene the reader encounters two methods of establishing evidence. The document calls the ramp "new," while the object shows an old crack beneath a fresh coat of paint. Lalit's signature may become more than his name: it may be a public assurance about the safety of an object. The narrative tension at the outset, therefore, does not concern who committed a crime. It concerns the statement the artisan is being pressured to make beyond the limits of what he knows directly.

Urmila describes having slipped twice; Lalit sees an internal crack in the timber; Naira brings the two conflicting times recorded in the hospital laundry register. These are not interchangeable forms of evidence. Bodily experience indicates a risk of slipping; inspection of wood reveals signs of partial repair; the time records raise questions about the supposed moments when goods moved. Lalit makes clear that even if the ramp had been built, this would not prove that laundry crossed it at the recorded time. An unjustified leap from evidential ground to the proposition being established is stopped. Naira divides her notebook into three headings—bill, actual material work, and load testing—making these limits of knowledge concrete. The episode's importance lies in its continuity with Chapter 40's hospital registers: a new scene of craftsmanship does not offer a counterfeit solution to an older mystery.

Not an Exclusive Privilege over Public Safety, but the Artisan's Limited Authority

The municipal contractor's representative asks Lalit to sign, citing the wages held up for other workers. Examining the bill's language, Lalit says that a receipt for materials, timber actually fitted, and a certified load are not the same thing. The official replies, "That is how the language of work

operates," expressing one institutional rationale in the story: the convenience of paperwork takes precedence over the object's actual state. Lalit, however, does not claim every kind of expertise for himself. Paro, a stone cutter, identifies a different risk in the wet earth below, but does not assume authority to certify the entire load-bearing structure. Salim, a farrier, tightens the bolts on the handcart while distinguishing the inspection of an empty cart from its safety under a heavy load. The distribution of different objects of knowledge among workers on the same site provides concrete material for the novel's Tattvachintamani-related reflection on evidence.

In the chapter's twenty-fifth passage Lalit also avoids assigning blame. The present condition of an old ramp does not establish that the contractor must have committed theft. Materials prepared elsewhere, the actual place of their use, and the original file still need examination. In this restraint, the artisan's refusal to sign is not merely a negative act; it is a positive ethical decision to keep his testimony within its proper limits. Yet the weight of the decision falls upon his private life in the form of debt, wages, and household expenses. If the story presented Lalit only as an unblemished hero, it would have little need for his calculations about selling old tools after losing the contract, his worry over a younger worker's wages, and his silence in the evening. The presence of this personal cost makes resistance a living scene.

Five Distinct Economic Interests: "All Workers" Are Not One Character

Uma Rajdhob, Paro the stone cutter, Salim the farrier, Gurmeet Kaur, and Rukhsana meet at the same place, but their demands cannot be collapsed into one collective declaration. Clothes belonging to Uma's private clients are not articles under the hospital contract; she needs separate recognition of her name in the ghat timetable and receipts. Naira does not record Uma's clients' private names in her notebook. Uma postpones a decision about cooperative washing because the clients' permission is outstanding. Paro wants payment for cutting her sample but will not assume liability for the entire load on unreliable ground. Salim considers training in new vehicle components alongside traditional farriery, though he has not decided to undertake it. Gurmeet enters charitable donations and paid cooking labour under separate headings at the community meal. The parallel-history view of occupational life thus moves beyond a register of names to a fuller condition of tasks, rights, and uncertain consequences.

Uma's observation that entering work at the ghat under one team's name would erase what another worker is owed by private customers resembles the crisis of the "complete package" rate sheet in Chapter 39. Yet these are

not identical disputes. There the question concerned charges for different operations on manufactured cloth; here it concerns time using a place and accounts for private customers. Gurmeet's food song evokes the possibility of shared celebration, but Uma continues counting her customers' items even while singing. The small scene refuses to dissolve labour into a festival. Instead, the coexistence of song and accounting expresses the difficult practical conditions of community. Organisers decide that the "Boat and Tools Inspection" will record the owner's name, inspection date, facts actually certified, and matters left unexamined. Hira herself forbids treating the demonstration at the event as equivalent to an official load test. The festival is a popular means of communicating knowledge, not a substitute for technical proof.

Dividing the Signature: Decision, Consequences, and Time

Lalit ultimately signs an inspection slip with three written conditions: the old ramp has been partly repaired; a temporary alternative route may be marked out for an empty or lightly loaded cart; and a separate technical test is necessary for a new incline or the load-bearing capacity required by heavy carts. He does not sign the original bill authorising payment. Refusal is accompanied here by a practical proposal delimiting how much work can safely proceed. But the next order promptly removes the contract from Lalit and makes room for another artisan to be appointed; the old dues are again subjected to review. The immediate loss of a livelihood is not obscured by celebrating the "victory" of withholding a signature. Naira's preservation of a copy of the order is a future-oriented step, not an appeal already won.

Narrative time runs from morning to evening on a single day. Memories of Lalit's teacher Harikishun and mention of a rope test on the boat the previous year provide short analepses. These memories explain why objects need retesting; this chapter has no independent scene from the ancient Mahabharata. The narrative's suggestion of a "dual-temporal intertext" is not here firm evidence of an independent mythological time-scene. Unlike the explicit Ballava and Brihannala episodes in Chapters 37 and 38, no such scene occurs. The mythological concealment associated with the Virata Parva may offer a structural echo—the wood called "new" on paper is actually old—but that metaphor must not be presented as an explicitly narrated mythical event.

Direct Perception, Inference, and Ethical Evaluation

In the vocabulary of narrative evidence, the object directly inspected is "the condition of the ramp seen here." "Heavy vehicles may safely use it on the basis of this bill" is a much broader proposition for which the grounds are insufficient. A fresh coat of paint, a materials receipt, or the repair of

one component does not establish a reliable connection sufficient to guarantee the load-bearing safety of the whole structure. Wet soil beneath it, water levels, the boat's route, and the cart's condition are indispensable matters for examining qualifying conditions. Even so, the use of the classical term upadhi is not a literal synonym for a modern engineering inspection; for the critic it is only a helpful analogy for recognising an unjustified extension in the structure of reasoning.

The chapter's particular literary achievement is to make the signature matter not merely as an assertion against falsehood, but as a conflict between bodily risk and the cost of earning a living. The crack in the wet plank, Lalit's injured hand, Paro's tilting stone, and the rice cooling on a plate make the argument materially perceptible. A limitation is that almost every artisan who appears speaks with an unusually similar caution about evidence; for some readers this may suggest a disciplined workshop more than spontaneous polyphony. The real damage caused by the lost contract, Uma's uncertain arrangements for her clients, and Gurmeet's humour partly break the uniformity. The soil, Shakuntala, and a child's notebook at the end provide the entry into the following chapter, not the solution to the present crisis over wood.

Chapter 42 — The Future of Clay

Touching Two Lumps: Similarity of Colour and Difference of Substance

In the morning Shakuntala Pandit sets two lumps of clay beside the potter's wheel—one smooth, the other gritty. Her granddaughter notices their similar colour, but Shakuntala points to tests of resistance to water, shrinkage in drying, and durability in firing. The novel's discussion of evidence is extended in a precise way by this scene: outward resemblance is insufficient identification; one must observe the material's behaviour in the work for which it is intended. The child notices the uneven rim of a half-made bowl, and Shakuntala allows her the opportunity to recognise a mistake. Craft knowledge is not presented as a fixed command handed down by inheritance, but as freedom to experiment. This opening connects with the sample of the tilting stone in Chapter 41, although clay for pottery and earth used as load-bearing fill at the ghat are not materials performing the same function. Lalit is himself the first to acknowledge the difference.

The granddaughter's new school uniform, the overlong sleeves of a kurta sewn by Nasim, and the worry that clay may stain it form a small scene of domestic realism. The child says she wants to learn to use the wheel, but she has not said that she wishes to do only that work throughout her life.

By the chapter's end, this statement becomes an early seed of self-determination. The creative achievement is that the conflict between education and occupation is not an externally imposed binary of "traditional versus modern." Shakuntala is herself an experienced artisan and wants to preserve skill, but she does not wish to determine her granddaughter's future in advance. The difference is subtle: not contempt for tools but refusal of occupational destiny. It gives the story's social meaning greater firmness.

The Gate at the Clay Site: Grounds for Prohibition and Their Scope

A sign on the path to the potters' clay site reads, "Entry Prohibited for Safety Reasons." The earth collapsed during the previous rainy season, a risk Shakuntala herself witnessed. She does not dismiss every reason for the prohibition as fabricated. Instead she asks who, and under whose order, has also closed a route that might be kept separate from the dangerous edge and judged safe. The notice bears a date but does not clearly name the issuing authority; this incomplete record cannot support a final decision about rights. Tara Mallik measures the length of the enclosure, water marks, and the location of excavation; she does not certify ownership, the properties of the clay, or that further collapse cannot occur. The narrative keeps questions of physical conditions distinct from questions of administrative authority.

Niru Kumal's proposal to operate a shared kiln also tests solidarity against personal liability. A supplier's document would make every artisan fully responsible for other people's debts of which they had no knowledge. Niru is willing to share fuel and keep daily accounts, but not to take undisclosed liabilities into her own name. Shakuntala tells Niru to label her clay samples separately and insists that the terms of collective work first be settled by the artisans in their own language. Lalit offers help with writing, but Shakuntala does not immediately put the authority to decide into somebody else's hands. This small act of resistance brings out the difference between "assistance with writing" and "the right to determine policy."

Clay Receipts, Payment for Pots, and Four Distinct Claims

Shakuntala's old ledger contains four consignments of pottery, one repair order, and two receipts. The two receipts acknowledge that goods were collected, not that payment was made. The vessels were counted for a municipal event, but the amounts owing remained unpaid. Now that the closing of the gate has been raised, a proposal is put to her to accept "half the old price in full settlement." The economic dispute is not automatically resolved by testing clay samples: the old claim originated in completed objects and labour. Kamlesh, a metalware worker, has separate

accounts for his shop rent and customers' unpaid repair charges. He wants to put the proposed rent before a public committee without disclosing clients' private possessions or names. His shop has not closed; next month's rent remains undecided.

Materials used for filling a road and for making pots are both called "clay" or "earth," but the estimate for the fill and the consignment receipts for pottery establish different responsibilities. A young man suggests possible theft; Naira stops him from treating that suggestion as evidence of a crime. The preliminary examination shows only that the shared word cannot support identifying two payment chains as one. The original entry order, actual transport slips, and a separate inspection of a safe route are needed. Niru's proposal does not result in the official permanently opening the gate. What is accepted is an application for a site visit with artisans, an engineer, and municipal representatives, together with a promise to obtain the original order. Shakuntala copies the receipt number. This number is limited evidence that a petition has been filed, not a judicial recognition of the claim.

Officials suggest extinguishing all dues with one "settlement amount." Shakuntala distinguishes payment for four consignments, repair labour, and workdays lost because the road was closed. Accepting a lesser amount is not the same as acknowledging that every amount due has been settled. Her decision not to sign structurally resembles Lalit's decision in Chapter 41, but its object is different. Lalit declines technical approval for unsafe heavy vehicles in the future; Shakuntala refuses an economic agreement extinguishing specified debts from the past. The word "refusal" applies in both cases, but the legal and economic consequences are not identical.

Amina, Vibha, and Household Labour: The Freedom of Small Enterprises

Amina Bhathiyara's food business gives the chapter another narrative plane. Uniformed employees who have come for an inspection say the meal will be paid for later under the heading of "public service." Amina asks for a receipt and an exact date: she is willing to feed hungry people, but regards the decision to make a donation as her own. One employee's irritation and another's agreement to issue a payment receipt mark a small turn in the scene. Elsewhere, Vibha Agrahari separately records quantities of first-aid materials for workers, purchase prices, selling prices, and possible free distribution. She does not claim that she is competent to give a medical diagnosis. The distinct entitlements involved in medicine, donation, and sale are thus immediately visible.

When Amina considers buying Shakuntala's still-untested vessels for hot dal, Shakuntala says that their ability to withstand fire, hold water, and

remain durable has not yet been tested. Amina puts the sample back. At that moment the labour value of the potter's work and the consumer safety obligations of the food seller are not opposed to each other: an object that has not completed scientific testing should not be sold immediately in the name of "supporting employment." The everyday action lends the chapter's epistemological argument greater credibility. Kamlesh's protection of customer confidentiality, Niru's refusal of undisclosed debt, Amina's bill, and Vibha's limits concerning medicines are small, independent commercial choices, not a single collective ethical slogan.

The Granddaughter's Education: The Echo of Tradition and Speech Directed Towards the Future

Shakuntala signs the school admission slip as the child's guardian. The girl asks whether she may learn to measure earth, understand water routes, and work on bridges. Lalit speaks of sharing practical skills, but recognises that definitive testing of a bridge's safety belongs to trained specialists. The child worries that if she chooses another profession, who will turn her grandmother's potter's wheel? Shakuntala does not erase the economic difficulty underlying the question. Her hands ache and the household may depend upon the child's help. She leaves open such difficult possibilities as taking less work, employing an additional worker, or learning a new method. The achievement is not that household resources suddenly become available; it is that the child's desire is not immediately shut down in the name of family poverty.

In the final image the granddaughter draws the circle of the wheel, the path to the clay site, and the school doorway on three pages of her notebook. One hand, three different paths: this pictorial arrangement is closely related to the two lumps of clay at the opening. Just as the material called clay has different possible uses, a person has several possible paths through life; yet the analogy is not a complete philosophical equivalence but an open resonance in the language of craft. In terms of rasa, the old artisan's worries, the granddaughter's enthusiasm, and economic uncertainty do not produce a simple excitement of triumph. They bring compassion, familial affection, and possibility into a shared composition. At the close the clay is still wet, payment remains outstanding, the gate remains shut, and school expenses are unresolved. The narrative gives meaningful form to the question of the future without declaring that future solved.

Narrative Time, Categories of Evidence, and the Examination of Limits

This chapter unfolds in the modern temporal strand from a single morning to night. Memories of transporting clay during the previous monsoon and of Shakuntala learning the wheel from her father are limited analepses. There is no independent scene from Janaka's age or another ancient temporal strand; the declared narrative coordinates of "documents and testimony; water and place imagery; labour and society" are principally borne out by the actual text. Focalisation stays close to Shakuntala's touch, the household's unpaid dues, and her granddaughter's questions. Naira is not the owner of every fact here but an assistant in separating the documents. Tara's measurements explicitly acknowledge the limits of what they establish.

From the standpoint of inference, similarity of colour does not prove that substances possess identical properties. The single word "earth" does not turn construction fill, raw material for pottery, and ownership of land into one thing. That a danger at an entry point is genuine does not prove that every condition for keeping the whole route closed is necessary: additional facts concerning place, time, and authority are required. The chapter's achievement is that the artisan's tactile knowledge is neither reduced to folk knowledge hostile to science nor elevated into the sole adequate source for technical testing. Its limitation is the readiness of nearly every supporting character to formulate written distinctions: at times the narrative risks allowing an administrative lesson to dominate the story. Yet the child's oversized sleeves, the unfinished bowl, Shakuntala's aching hands, and Amina's time spent serving food give experiential density to these abstract distinctions.

Chapter 43 — The Brassworker and the Goldsmith

The Ring of Metal: Repair, New Objects, and the Limits of Pricing

The chapter opens with three blows of a hammer on Meena Sah's old brass vessel. The sound of the first two strokes and the tremor of the cracked joint under the third reveal Meena's combined tactile and auditory expertise. There is an order to make the hospital's old vessels fit for a new use; Meena says she will charge for repair, not for new vessels. The object is old and its use is changing, but the mere new name assigned to that use cannot determine its price. In this material opening, there is no literal character from the Virata Parva's episode of life in disguise; nevertheless, the inequality between name, work, and object acquires concrete narrative form. Nor has the complete safety of the repaired object, described as new, yet been established: Meena cannot return the vessel to its customer without filling it with water and testing it that night. The arc from opening to conclusion makes responsibility for craftsmanship visible.

Urmila's hospital laundry register reverses the times when a vehicle arrived and when goods were collected. Meena has repaired two brass vessels, although at one point the hospital delivery note seemed to indicate "three repairs." Naira does not regard the laundry, utensils, and medical treatment accounts as proof of a single offence. Subsequent examination establishes that the third mark denotes a separate tax column for labour, not another repair: a genuine correction of an error. Yet a discrepancy remains between receipt of the four objects recorded on the delivery note and their actual use. The distribution of truth within the narrative matters here. Correcting one false allegation does not make every irregularity imaginary; conversely, one remaining discrepancy does not restore an allegation shown to be wrong. Meena's direct knowledge extends only to the arrival, repair, and return of two objects.

Kamala the Goldsmith's "Head of Household": The Verbal Erasure of Ownership

At Kamala Thakur's goldsmith's shop, an elderly woman and a young man advance conflicting claims of ownership over a pledged bangle. The young man refers to a loan the father took out for business; the elderly woman maintains that the bangle was her personal property, received from her maternal home. The register has separate fields for weight, metal testing, signatures, and creditor, yet the earlier ownership field says "head of household." A single archival phrase presents domestic power as though it were a legal fact. The elderly woman's question—rather than asking who headed the household, ask who deposited the bangle herself—turns the missing name from a mere clerical mistake into a question of property

rights. Kamala hears both parties separately; speaking more loudly confers no priority of proof.

The asymmetrical bent flower inside the bangle awakens the elderly woman's memory. The mark left on an object has considerable narrative effect: it offers a visible means of emotional recognition that the woman connects with the history of her own body. Kamala, however, does not immediately pronounce ownership on the strength of that mark. She asks for the old deposit slip, witnesses, and separate verification of who benefited from the loan. Later a witness says that the elderly woman herself removed the bangle, although the receipt was issued in a male family member's name. Kamala cannot unilaterally rewrite the old account; she attaches the woman's claim to it. The elderly woman obtains a supplementary copy bearing her name, not a final settlement of the property dispute. Meena's corrected numerical error and Kamala's unresolved ownership claim are two different states of adjudication.

A realist reading must also ask whether treating the bent flower as sufficient evidence of ownership would grant the woman's experience an evidentiary privilege beyond the classical distinctions among kinds of proof. The story avoids that easy solution. The mark on the object is "helpful in identification"; when the property was acquired, who had the right to pledge it, and on what terms the debt was contracted require separate answers. Kamala is not an instantly effective ideal judge but a professional custodian of records with limited powers. Her credibility lies in acknowledging those limits.

Five Separate Claims Concerning Craft, Design, and Credit

Rekha Sahu, a maker of lac bangles, designs a new curve patterned on a river. A customer plans to pass the design to a machine-based shop but does not reckon its price separately. Rekha demands permission and payment for the measurements and design, apart from manufacturing costs. Usha Ram requests an independent labour receipt for repairing drum leather and making a new joint in a shoe: a singer's fee and the charge for repairing a dholak are not the same. In the proposed sale of Bindeshwari Sahu's old oil press, the physical equipment, repayment of debt, family memory, and cost of starting a new enterprise are separate considerations. Gomati raises the question of extra wages for her labour group's effort in carrying sacks of wet lime. These four scenes do not simply reiterate the message "name the maker." Reproduction rights, repair wages, exchange of property, and measurement of labour time have independent economies.

The conversation between Rekha and Kamala about the bent flower is particularly subtle. Unevenness of form is not necessarily a defect in

craftsmanship; but a rough bangle edge that chafes the wearer's hand must be corrected. In the first instance the bent flower is a sign of personal memory; in the second, the rough corner of a bangle is a risk in use. The distinction between "beautiful" and "safe" becomes immediately perceptible. The elderly woman herself asks whether Rekha's bangle will be comfortable to wear, and Rekha tests it again against the mould. Mutual testing occurs through action rather than a verbal lesson. Usha's design receipt for the new shoe joint likewise constitutes partial support in a dispute over professional credit; no final judicial decision on copying has yet been made.

Bindeshwari's consideration of selling the oil press is joined by an elderly woman's memory of a lamp and her insistence on saving the old measuring vessel. Selling an object to pay off family debt and preserving memories of an older skill need not exclude each other. At the close of the domestic discussion, a proposal to keep the measuring vessel, signboard, and old ledger is accepted; however, no definitive signature authorising the sale of the press is given. A new valuation from the buyer is expected two days later. This incomplete agreement signifies recognition of the costs of social change. It does not establish that a possible new oil business has become a successful enterprise. Nor is the conflict between the older woman's memory and modern economic judgment merely "new generation versus old," for Bindeshwari too is attached to those memories.

Shell, Lime, and the Unknown Fourth Object: The Time and Place of Evidence

At the hospital warehouse, Gomati's labour group says it transported sacks labelled "lime." What substance was actually inside them, who held it, and where it was used lie outside the workers' direct experience. The warehouse delivery note bears a "materials received" stamp, but the field for "place of use" is blank. Meena knows about repairing two brass objects; the third mark proves to be a tax column; the question of an unidentified fourth article remains open. Naira records the moment of receipt and the site of use as two separate questions for investigation. The workers' testimony therefore does not determine the complete nature of the material. It does, however, independently establish the day of transport, the work performed, and the wages owed.

This is a remarkable narratological moment because Gomati's voice does not remain merely a source of information for the investigators. She directly presents the outstanding payment for the extra labour of carrying wet sacks. Whether the search for an offence ends or is suspended does not extinguish what the workers are owed. The separate wage column created in the ledger offers a useful interpretive point for Videha Parallel History:

alongside a prominent official inventory, an independent economic history of less visible workers can be written. That does not, however, make the novel's imagined scenes independently verified historical records. Literature reveals questions about social absence; historical writing beyond the text requires independent sources.

The Strength of a Polycentric Narrative and the Risk of Accumulation

The narrative spans a modern day, from morning to night. Meena and Urmila's hospital episode, Kamala's property dispute, Rekha's design, Usha's leather and shoe work, Bindeshwari's oil press, and Gomati's warehouse labour are set alongside one another either simultaneously or at different moments of the day. The third-person narrator describes the characters' social circumstances without opening each consciousness to the same extent. Meena's and Kamala's work receives detailed dramatic treatment; the conversation in Bindeshwari's household releases the emotions of memory; Gomati's brief testimony opens an important door into social history. This is not a plot confined to the inner life of one "heroine," but a polycentric marketplace narrative gathered together through objects and accounts.

The question of the four items on the delivery note is held open from the chapter's beginning to its end, while five occupational plotlines intervene. Richness also carries a danger: the sequence of character introductions and claims of rights can begin to resemble a display demonstrating the successful representation of 157 occupations. Naira, Meena, Kamala, Usha, Rekha, and Gomati all tend to arrive at nearly the same verbal formula for separating kinds of evidence. Yet life-specific memories—the bent flower inside the bangle, the lamp beside the oil press, the rough edge of a bangle, the wet sack—reduce this mechanical quality. The story diverts attention from the central hospital discrepancy: this is both an advantage of its many voices and a potential obstruction to narrative momentum.

From the standpoint of narrative evidence, the inference from "three similar marks" to "three repairs" proves wrong; correcting the classification of the sign yields a proper reading. The stamp "materials received" is not conclusive proof that "materials were used at the designated site"; the whole intervening chain of work must be established separately. The elderly woman's bent flower assists identification of the object but does not fully establish the right of ownership. In one chapter, numerical reading, the location of an object, and ownership constitute three distinct evidentiary crises. It would be mistaken to flatten this diversity into a simple opposition between "documents" and "people." The narrative's achievement is to hold corrected error and surviving uncertainty together; its limitation is the potentially unnatural extension of identical argumentative competence to every character.

Chapter 44 — The Blacksmith's Tools

The Thin Strip in the Forge and the Digital Headline of Fear

The yellow fire in Harinarayan Sharma's forge, the groove in a thin strip on the anvil, and measurements in Ajit's notebook establish craftsmanship as a directly observable process at the chapter's opening. A photograph circulating on mobile phones removes most of that process from view. The picture retains a rod and a bent iron plate, while its caption declares that weapons are being manufactured near the hospital warehouse. Four distinct objects are actually present in the workshop: a hook for opening a drainage grille, an axle pin for a handcart, a loom clamp, and a ring for securing a boat rope. Cropping the photograph changes the interpretation of the objects' actual uses. The episode relates to the "child thief" rumour of Chapter 29 and the premature publication in Chapter 20, but its subject is not an alleged missing child. It is the communicative act of declaring ordinary metal tools to be instruments of violence.

Harinarayan does not say that an implement can never be used for another, potentially violent purpose. When a constable asks whether a tool might have a different use, he answers that possibility and evidence of work actually performed at this site are different matters. The distinction is crucial. Criticism should not attempt to prove the absolute "innocence" of an ordinary tool but should examine the degree to which the allegation has been substantiated. The possibility that an object could serve violence in one setting does not show that the artisan made it for violence on this occasion. The evidentiary questions concern dimensions, the customer's order, the observed use of the component, and the actual conditions of manufacture. To attach an inherent moral fault or virtue to iron would contradict the story's reasoning.

Ajit's Perspective and Naira's Earlier Error: Near and Distant Focalisation

Seeing his father's reputation attacked, Ajit wants to pronounce the person who sent the photograph guilty at once. Harinarayan stops him: suffering from one wrong does not entitle them to make an accusation against another person on the basis of a similar assumption. This small father-son exchange places the chapter's ethical argument within human relationships. Ajit's recording of actual measurements in his notebook is not merely an administrative rebuttal; it is the act of an emerging artisan learning to train his own eyes. The narrator does not offer an exhaustive internal analysis of his anger, but creates close focalisation through his steady hand, puffed cheeks, and unspoken question.

Naira remembers her earlier error in publishing Mahesh's testimony prematurely. She now restricts public statements to three categories: what appears in the photograph, what was directly examined in the workshop, and what remains in question. She recognises two dangers together: spreading a false accusation and preventing the legitimate examination of a possible clue. In this sense Naira is not an entirely reliable, omniscient judge; memory of her previous mistake has taught her to limit the authority of her own statements. Narrative development is enacted through conduct. She challenges the wording of the inspection copy, requiring "inspected" to replace "recovered." Describing an object that was never seized as "recovered" could have furnished future readers or offices with grounds for a false conclusion.

Irfan's Axle and Brake: Do Not Turn a Crisis of Expertise into Heroism

Irfan Khan arrives with a worn bushing from vehicle repair. His order slip records the vehicle axle, the date, and the mark on the old component. One of his customer's passenger vehicles transports workers and patients; entering a complaint about brake noise might jeopardise the customer's contract. Irfan acknowledges that the defect requires another examination, but does not wish to conceal the wear he has already observed. The structure of his decision resembles Lalit's predicament—fear of lost income set against the truth of inspection—although the events are distinct. Lalit's contract has actually been withdrawn; Irfan might lose a customer. This is a possibility, not an event that has occurred.

Irfan demonstrates a component's observed use to the police, but does not testify about a part replaced in another workshop. Naira writes down his three words: "seen, done, heard." The classification helps establish the status of sources in verbal testimony: an observation made with one's own eyes, a task performed with one's own hands, and an account heard from someone else do not carry the same evidentiary standing. Even this simple formula is not final truth, however. The meaning of what has been seen depends on context, technical tests require sound methods, and an artisan's memory is not infallible. This critical qualification is necessary to connect the novel's reasoning with practical judgment.

Farzana, Rekha, and Sharda: From the Photograph of Tools to Rights in the Market

Farzana the bangle-maker distinguishes handmade lac bracelets, glass bangles, and machine-made goods. Her mixture of colours and movement of the hand are not simply copies of Rekha Sahu's new design; she explains the particular costs and durability of her own craft. Before customers she demonstrates that tools can resemble one another while serving different purposes. This implicitly rebuts the photograph's indiscriminate

classification of tools as "weapons": tongs, clamps, grips for hot lac, and wooden moulds have different functions. Her niece chooses a grey-green bracelet with her own money. Farzana enters an agreed discount on the receipt, rather than arbitrarily calling it a "donation." In this lightly humorous domestic scene, the space for personal preference survives within a market beset by fear.

Sharda Kasaudhan's old pawn ledger contains repeated interest charges, entries that read "family" instead of a woman's name, and ambiguous payments for redeeming pledged objects. This connects with Kamala the goldsmith's ownership dispute, but Kamala does not share the elderly woman's private claim documents with Sharda without permission. In her own shop, Sharda proposes separate columns for principal, interest, and ownership. At a family meeting, her brother agrees to correct one duplicated interest charge. The whole of the old account has not been opened, nor have all pledges been redeemed. The significance of this limited change is that a traditional prohibition on economic transparency is breached for the first time, even though the entire system remains unchanged.

Farzana's proposal to show children the craft with cool moulds and safe samples places child safety alongside the "sharing of knowledge." Rekha reminds them that training has a real price. This episode has a distant relation to Ekalavya's right to education in Chapter 31, the itinerant school in Chapter 36, and Ruhani's class in Chapter 38. Learning a craft is different from extracting unpaid labour from its instructor. No new school has yet begun here; the scene remains at the level of planning and practical policy judgment.

The Inspection Decision and Its Social Cost

The constable and municipal team examine the four tools' dimensions, the customers' orders, and their direct uses. That day, they find no material evidence in the workshop supporting the specific allegation that weapons are being made. In the amended inspection slip, the articles are described as "inspected." A separate inquiry into an external consignment or independent complaint remains open. A correction stating that the accusation was not substantiated is posted on the municipal noticeboard; nevertheless, Nandlal does not immediately restore his order for a ploughshare, and no public apology is issued. This uneven temporal rhythm matters. A proper document rebutting the charge can be produced in a day; economic restoration of trust cannot happen at once.

The narrator does not reduce the injury to a commonplace moral lesson about defamation. Customers' fear, the workshop's uncertain income, and Ajit's concern for his father remain within the story. Yet there are no

reliable figures for a precise business loss, so a critic must not invent the number of rupees lost under the guise of measuring damage. The municipal noticeboard constitutes a correction in a public record; it is not proof that every original copy on social media has been removed. This delimitation highlights the unequal reach of the digital photograph at the beginning and the local notice at the end.

Fire, Iron, and the Unfinished Rattle

The day at the forge passes into night. Ajit makes a small rattle out of waste iron pieces. Two of its three pieces sound, but the third does not. He changes the spacing and obtains three different notes, though one edge is still rough; his father says it remains to be filed smooth. At the opening the iron "point" in the photograph provoked fear; at the close, smoothing an iron edge to protect a child's hand is work still to be done. This opening-and-ending recurrence gives contradictory meanings: the same material may be socially labelled violent, yet its actual craftsmanship can create music. The episode does not declare the object intrinsically sacred. It emphasises the continuing process of completing, testing, and making it safe.

Narrative time is chiefly linear, covering one day from morning to night. Memories of the earlier mobile-phone circulation, publication of Mahesh's testimony, and Lalit's lost contract function as antecedent information. No independent time of mythic characters appears in this chapter. One could compare the structural term "disguise" from the Virata Parva with the deceptive effects of digital imagery, but the text offers no proof that such a comparison is an authorised narrative equivalence. The third-person narrator opens the workshop scene, then shifts among Naira, Irfan, Farzana, and Sharda's separate places of business. These different viewpoints create a sense of community, although the characters' similar habit of saying "first measure, obtain a receipt, investigate separately" risks repetition.

The achievement of the evidentiary analysis is that a potentially different use remains distinct from a proven present purpose; inspection from seizure; correction of a rumour from compensation for harm; and loan principal from interest. These recurring distinctions are indispensable ethical subjects, but the novel could have trusted the reader to recognise some of them through scenes rather than repeatedly making characters announce them. On the other hand, Ajit's rattle, Farzana's discount receipt, Irfan's bushing, and the heat of the forge translate the intellectual scheme into material, temporal, and bodily experience. The final handiwork is not "finished"—a rough edge still requires filing. This is a precise miniature image of an ethically open narrative development.

Virata Parva / Aranya Kanda: Comparative Criticism of Chapters 41–44

Four Openings, Four Objects of Examination, Four Incomplete Outcomes

The structure of these four chapters is planned to a degree: at dawn artisans touch their materials; a public document or accusation begins to alter the meaning of an object; people from several communities come together; and by evening a partial correction has been made. This recurrence sharpens the question of material evidence. Nevertheless, the specificity of the events prevents their complete absorption into a mechanical series. Chapter 41 centres on the unverified load-bearing safety of a wooden unloading ramp; Chapter 42 on an obstructed clay site and unpaid pottery; Chapter 43 on metal repairs, pledged property, and a delivery note recording four objects; Chapter 44 on an image of tools, the wording of an inspection, and reputational damage. In the first, a contract is actually lost; in the second, an application for access is accepted; in the third, a misreading is corrected; and in the fourth, an inspection-based rebuttal of a public allegation is issued. To call these outcomes "the resolution of every dispute" would erase the negative evidence in the narrative.

Time, Place, and Focalisation: The Modern Workshop of the Virata Parva

In all four chapters, the present-day cycle of morning, noon, and evening or night predominates. A wet crack in timber, the smooth clay on a potter's wheel, the tremor of brass, and the strike of iron on an anvil provide four different sensory openings. Through this material perception, the narrator attempts to establish each occupation's particularity. Naira then moves between locations, connecting several enquiries into evidence; yet her memory of her earlier publication error and her decision to retain only limited copies prevent her from becoming an omniscient centre. Lalit's economic worry, Shakuntala's aching hands, the time needed for Meena's joint repair, and Harinarayan's fear of losing customers generate distinct personal focalisations. The achievement of the four chapters is that, even without scenes populated by ancient mythic figures, the everyday magnitude of modern craftsmanship can be explored within an epic structure. Although mythological characters do not literally enter, the question "whose name will stand as a symbol for whose work?" remains alive.

The Classification of Evidence and Narratology: The Refusal of Excessive Claims

Four inferences require intermediate proof: from "a fresh coat of paint" to an entirely new and safe ramp; from the word "clay" to an identical substance; from "three marks" to three repairs; and from "a shape resembling a rod" to the manufacture of weapons. The actual place of use, the water level, material testing, the original design, and the customer's order supply modern illustrations of how qualifying conditions must be examined. Nevertheless, this literary analogy cannot take the place of modern technical laboratory standards. When the classifications of evidence in the Tattvachintamani are invoked for comparison, the historical contexts of the original philosophical terms require separate examination; the novel's dialogue is not an authenticated quotation from the treatise. Nor should the Nyayakusumanjali's question of unseen causes be treated as directly identical to every mystery of an unseen bill. In these four chapters, "unseen" in ordinary speech means a detail of an object not yet examined; its technical meaning in philosophy remains distinct.

Videha Parallel History: Workers' Voices and the Risk of Listing

The narratives of Uma, Paro, Salim, Shakuntala, Niru, Kamlesh, Amina, Vibha, Meena, Kamala, Rekha, Usha, Bindeshwari, Gomati, Irfan, Farzana, Sharda, and Harinarayan raise questions from which separate histories of communities could begin: in whose name is the wage recorded, whose hands made the object, who owns the design or pledged property, whose time was spent repairing it, and who benefits from a public correction? These literary scenes disclose the possibility of histories of unrecorded labour but cannot replace actual history. Differences among each character's occupation, community, and decisions must be preserved; skills or moral qualities cannot be inferred automatically from a caste or community name. The author's scheme of 157 occupational communities has the significant ambition of creating a vast world of labour. Its limitation is that scenes may successively become demonstrations of occupations and lessons in issuing acknowledgements. To examine this risk, later chapters must be tested for unforeseen changes in characters, conflicts of interest, failure, and enduring relationships with memory.

Literary Achievement, Contradictions, and Questions for the Chapters Ahead

The artistic strength of this section lies in sensory images of particular objects, uneven economic consequences, and the recurrence of incomplete decisions. Lalit's contract is not saved; the expense of Shakuntala's granddaughter's future remains a question; Meena still seeks the fourth

material; and Harinarayan's customers do not immediately regain trust. The narrative's ethical achievement is to make "investigation" more than a device for catching the guilty: it becomes a process of clearing the innocent of unsupported accusations, recognising workers' wages, and ensuring the safe use of objects. But as this conception is repeatedly articulated, the prose risks losing its natural multiplicity of voices; Naira and characters in different trades frequently speak in a similarly legalistic, evidentiary idiom. Opposing officials and customers sometimes have recognisable desires, economic constraints, and human complexity, yet too often they provide opportunities for the main characters to demonstrate correct distinctions. It would not be impartial criticism to deny this potentially didactic tendency.

The inward images closing these four chapters are, in succession, Lalit's gaze towards the earth, the granddaughter's lines marking three paths, Meena's vessel awaiting the water test, and Ajit's rattle still needing to be filed smooth. These outcomes embodied in objects intensify the fundamental conflict of Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind: how much does a person know when making a promise, who bears its cost, and can a responsible decision be made with incomplete knowledge? The structure in which work continues, rather than a claim that every problem is solved, opens this middle section of the Virata Parva towards the coming chapters on tools, materials, and rights over land.

Chapter 45 — The Weaver's Consignment

The Wet Path beside the Cattle Shed: Labour Distribution Begins with a Scene

The chapter opens with water dripping from the roof of Sukathi's cattle shed and Vinod Kewat's fish market. Vinod empties water collected in a lid not over the fish baskets but into a container beside the drain. The next moment brings into focus the slippery path encountered by a small trader and the convenient space provided elsewhere for a heavy stationary vehicle. The water imagery is not merely symbolic decoration. The market's physical layout determines who obtains a dry place despite paying rent, whose stock spoils, and whose working day is shortened. Vinod's demand concerning rent and his demand for secure footing are different claims. Thus the problem of the "ghat" extends beyond river water to the market's drainage, wheels, and paving.

The arrival of Yusuf Ansari changes the meaning of the visible objects. Two bundles of cloth carry the same shop stamp, but the threads, joins, and selvedge of the loom-woven cloth in the first bear recognisable signs of Yusuf's labour; the construction of the second is unfamiliar. The second

bundle carries a printed label certifying approval for hospital use. Reading the label and touching the cloth become distinct moments of knowledge within the story. Yusuf does not claim to have carried out a conclusive examination by tearing open the bolts. He observes differences at the sample level and suspends the sale. The opening drama lies in this limited act: the lure of a higher price and an immediate debt on one side; the unverified claim about manufacture and hospital approval on the other.

Two Bundles, Three Records: Differences among Ownership, Manufacture, and Approval

The merchant's representative displays a combined bill for both bundles and the shop's stamp, but neither bears Yusuf's signature. The bill may establish that "goods circulated under this name"; it does not sufficiently prove that "this artisan wove these goods." Hospital "approval" requires a still more separate examination: the intended class of use, the purchase register, evidence of quality, and the identity of an authorised recipient. Yusuf keeps the order for the original bolt, its authentic sample, and the receipt separately; he ties a red thread to the second bundle to mark suspension of its sale. This decision does not seize the goods or amount to a court's identification of the manufacturer. It merely halts their commercial movement on the basis of a potentially false claim.

Naira's arrival gives her the role of editor of evidence. She takes photographs with the owner's permission, distinguishes the claim of manufacture from a visual description of the label, and asks to see the original hospital purchase register. Even though a shared vehicle number occurs on some hospital slips, she does not conclude that every sack came from one source or that missing hospital goods have been found here. The narrator divides the chain of evidence into loading, unloading, receipt, and use. A matching vehicle number may suggest a causal connection worth investigating, but it cannot independently identify the guilty party.

In narratological terms, if "the shop stamp" is offered as the reason and "Yusuf manufactured it" as the proposition to be proved, the necessary invariable relation is absent. A merchant may dispatch cloth from different makers under a single stamp; a shared vehicle may carry goods from several businesses. These alternatives are not merely vague doubts: they are supported in the story by the second bundle's different physical construction and the demand for separate loading records. Yet to claim that classical inference in the Tattvachintamani and modern testing of textiles follow an identical method would be untenable. The critical comparison is a means of identifying the limits of an argument, not a substitute for laboratory certification.

Vinod, Ramani, Suman, and Meena: The Economic Ground of Many Voices

Although the chapter is named for a weaver's consignment, its first viewpoint rests on Vinod's fish market. His ledger separately counts fish purchases, unloading from a boat, carrying baskets, and spoiled stock. In the accountant's register, sellers like him are classified as "miscellaneous." Vinod obtains a dated application for a place in the market under his individual name. This scene opens an evidentiary crisis in the history of unnamed labour: when a worker's costs are not separately counted, the public calculation of the resulting loss will also remain concealed. But entry of a name in the register does not amount to being allotted a permanent shelter; a decision is postponed until the next hearing.

At a gathering devoted to fish and makhana labour, Ramani Mallah demands distinct prices for picking, drying, cracking, and bringing makhana to market. Yusuf identifies thread costs and time at the loom; Vinod identifies the price of fish and spoiled goods; carriers demand separate transport charges. All reject a single price for "local goods." The committee creates four categories but does not approve rates. This is an actual narrative event, though a partial one: consideration of differentiated rates gains institutional entry in place of a uniform price. Social plurality here is not merely the appearance of several communities; it emerges from conflict between different methods of determining value.

Suman Tikulhar separately states a charge for using her coloured pattern and the broader right to reproduce her mould. Meena Sarki records the hire of leather straps, the labour of fastening them, and waiting time on different slips. Suman's coloured signs and Meena's leather straps raise questions of different materials, risks, and intellectual or material entitlements. Meena will not accept responsibility for securing the second, unverified bundle until that responsibility is clarified; half the payment for her waiting time is still outstanding at day's end. Instead of a single proposition that "all workers defend their rights," the episode shows partly distinct economic struggles. Nevertheless, the fact that four artisans speak in such orderly cost categories on the same day raises the designed structure of the story above the immediacy of its scenes. This possible didactic uniformity must be entered on the critical side of the assessment.

Domestic Time and Disagreement between Generations: The Person behind the Occupational Name

Yusuf's son is undertaking training in electronics and proposes matching sample numbers against photographs. His father objects that a photograph cannot convey the feel of a thread; the son does not deny tactile knowledge but wants to add a sample register to visual evidence. The

dialogue avoids setting digital and bodily knowledge against each other in a simple opposition. At night the father opens two separate financial pages —wages owed for the genuine bolt and expenses associated with the suspended consignment—alongside the due date of his son's training fee. This threefold register brings the truth of labour, commercial loss, and a family obligation directed towards the future together. The son wishes to help, not to sit at a loom all day and repeat the inherited profession. His father painfully accepts this right.

The chapter's principal time is linear, running from dawn until night; conversations from the previous evening, loans, and older orders enter as brief analepses. Although the narrator adopts an expansive third-person viewpoint, focalisation successively approaches Vinod's anxiety about expenses and Yusuf's knowledge of thread, shame, and household pressure. No clearly dramatised mythic Virata scene is present. The structural question of "disguise" arises through the unequal identities of two objects bearing the same stamp. This figure must not be described as a mythological scene actually present in the story. The silent loom at the end leaves both defeat and ethical victory incomplete: the falsely labelled material was not sold, but the losses were not reduced; the small trader's name was entered, but the allocation of space was not improved. The chapter's literary significance lies in this unresolved duality.

Chapter 46 — Washerfolk, Dyers, and Cotton Carders

Four Squares on One Board: A Narrative of Seeing Systematically

The story opens with a damp sheet belonging to Urmila Rajak. If the inner seams do not dry, the linen will smell in the hospital: this is a form of working knowledge that cannot be captured by receipt times alone. She places washed sheets and pieces whose counts do not reconcile in separate baskets. Renu then reports a rumour that all clothes arriving on the same vehicle should be treated as the hospital's missing property. Urmila asks who can testify about an object actually seen. Washing, dyeing, and cotton carding are not identical kinds of work. On a public board Naira creates four distinct columns—washing, dyeing, carding, and transport. These chalk lines do not themselves decide ownership; they simply permit evidence to be kept separate.

Rahim Mansuri's cotton-carding slip distinguishes the refluffing of seven mattresses, cotton for two new mattresses, and covers returned by three customers. Mahendra the carter acknowledges carrying four sacks. Seven jobs and four transported sacks are not necessarily contradictory totals: three customers collected their own goods. Here the narrator supplies a genuine explanation of an apparent numerical inconsistency, without

thereby proving the innocence or theft of the materials in every mattress. Sakina's two dyeing slips show a customer's revised order for one length of cloth, not another consignment. These differences allow the aggregate labour of production, the number of objects transported, and the count of customer orders to be calculated separately.

The Grocer's "White Material" and the Carter's Blurred Times

Harish the grocer declares the limits of his trade at the outset: he is not an expert in washing, dyeing, or stitching mattresses. His ledger lists salt, ajwain, bark, soap-making ingredients, and packing paper. The designation "white material" does not establish that a substance is a medically approved powder for cleaning hospital linen; neither colour nor outward appearance sufficiently establishes its use. When the outer label and inner sheet of a package give different names, Harish stops its sale and requests the original purchase bill. But he himself received this new package that day and does not claim that it was part of the previous day's shared vehicle consignment. Such fine discrimination reflects responsibility towards truth rather than a device for heightening the excitement of crime.

Mahendra's vehicle stopped at four places—the carder's courtyard, the dyer's lane, the hospital's rear unloading point, and the cattle enclosure—but two time entries are blurred on a wet slip. Contact with water is one possible explanation of the error, not a complete explanation of every discrepancy. Urmila's laundry register gives a receipt time earlier than completion of washing; a clerk suggests that the "order time" may have been entered instead. Urmila then demands separate records of actual labour hours and the time of the order. The original hospital register has not been stamped as amended. In this episode of non-establishment, the characters do more than "understand" the evidence: their livelihoods and the actual time when patients receive bedding are affected by the incorrect coding of time.

A Child's Photograph: The Return of an Old Rumour and the Limits of Consent

Amid the disputes about the gate and the cattle enclosure, a blurred photograph appears with a small figure behind a vehicle. A young man calls it proof that "a child was abducted"; in the actual scene the child was tying the strap of a sandal beside the road. The child's mother is willing to testify but does not want the child's face displayed on a public noticeboard. This does not mean that every possible child-safety concern has been dismissed. It means that publicly alleging abduction without establishing the photograph's time, person, circumstances, and permission can cause new harm. Although Chapters 29–30 contained a false accusation, the facts

of this new photograph require separate examination. Nor has any proven connection been established between this unidentified image and the continuing search for Mithun.

Naira's information policy here has two parts. If a real child is missing, a safe route for communicating information to the responsible authorities must remain open; however, a market noticeboard must not display a patient's name, a customer's household, or a child's face. Mahendra asks for a certificate of complete innocence, but instead of appointing herself a judge, Naira presents a comparison of the available slips. The ethical success of this writing lies in showing that the public use of the word "suspicion" can inflict personal damage. Its literary limitation is that the language of correcting errors recurs so often that some dialogue may sound more like a uniform current of the author's reasoning than the different voices of characters.

A Short Sentence on the Public Noticeboard: The Conflict between Rights and Publicity

To reduce the cost of writing a notice, the secretary proposes: "Suspect goods in a shared vehicle." Rahim's cotton, Sakina's dyes, and Urmila's sheets could all become objects of collective suspicion by implication. The corrected brief notice states instead that the vehicle number alone does not establish the source or an offence, and it invites submission of relevant slips. This is not a final communal legal judgment; it is a minimum discipline governing public communication. Its result is real: the procedure is explained to the public without a theatrical pronouncement. The source of the hospital's missing material and the merchant's false label, however, remains under investigation.

The chapter's ending opens the door to another examination through the gate's narrow passage. Renu reports that although the grille has been partly removed, the earth is still sinking. Urmila distinguishes ownership of goods from the practical accessibility of a route on foot. At night Naira writes down four separate subjects—the original register of names, the child rumour, the hospital inventory, and access along the water embankment—and says she will measure with Hira and Tara the following dawn. The plan establishes a clear causal link with the material work of Chapter 47. The source does not conclude that "all these mysteries are strands of the same crime."

Temporal Structure, Voice, and the Home at the End

The present-time sequence is linear, from the sheet at the morning ghat to Rahim's home at night. A brief recollection of Urmila's mother's illness enters the story, not to publicise a patient's personal history but to explain

the ethical significance of the labour time devoted to a sheet. The third-person narrator shifts attention among Urmila, Rahim, Sakina, Mahendra, and Naira in their differing social positions, although Naira's board remains the principal stage for examining discrepancies. The preliminary indication of a "two-temporal intertext" should not be taken as proof of an independent ancient Mahabharata scene in this chapter; there is no such scene in the complete original chapter. At the end Rahim gives his daughter a small safe piece of carded cotton for play. The touch of cotton, dust rising with breath, and a child's play bring ordinary working life back into view amid publicity surrounding alleged crime. The human warmth of the story lies in this temporary respite; the gate problem has not yet been resolved.

Chapter 47 — Measuring the Gate

The Bamboo Pole and Three Measurements with a Cord: Space Becomes an Event

The chapter opens with Hira Sahni's measuring pole: although the bed beneath the water feels firm, the pole sinks further into mud. The central question follows immediately: what is the reference point for measurement—the water surface, an iron pillar, slumped earth, or ground firm enough for wheels to pass safely? Municipal engineer Aditi's copy records an external width without explaining what the reference points mean. Tara Binaut distinguishes three different conditions; Urmila pushes an empty handcart to show that once the first wheel crosses, the second begins sliding on the slope. To undertake the same experiment with heavy loads of patients' linen would be inappropriate. Here the physical world drives the narrative event. The gate is not merely a metaphor: its actual narrowness generates obstacles to movement, lost wages, delays in transporting goods, and risks to safety.

Hira's practical experience and Aditi's engineering authority cannot simply be exchanged for one another. Hira explains that one measurement cannot establish safe passage for boats, pedestrians, handcarts, and motor vehicles; Aditi acknowledges that the remaining pages of the original old report must be examined. Tara's measurements specify the water level, time, and ground conditions. The public admission by all three inspectors of the limits of their knowledge strengthens the story's epistemological test. Yet extensive dialogue about procedure also suspends dramatic movement. To make each figure meaningful for the reader, the narrative needs living consequences such as Urmila's slipping cart and delays in delivering patients' linen.

The Mark of the Kareh, the Name of the Pebble, and the Status of Old Testimony

A representative of the irrigation embankment seeks to turn a dry line called "Kankar" into proof of a private watercourse based on its use by his employer's ancestors. Tara sees traces of an old water channel in the layers of soil but does not determine present property boundaries merely from hearing its name. Shyam's copy contains the word "Kareh" and two old marks. Tara's grandmother had recognised them, but it has not been established whether the stone remains in its original position or was moved. Here folk memory becomes evidence open to correction. It is neither dismissed as foolish superstition nor made the unquestionable measure of the whole truth about boundaries.

The mark preserved in the grandmother's memory, the brick found at the site, the old paper, and today's measurement constitute four distinct sources. Their correspondence can be investigated, but without continuity of time, place, and material, none can simply replace another. The distinction opens a critical possibility for Videha Parallel History: two women worked until nightfall searching for an old route, and the time they spent should count as paid labour. Their inquiry might ultimately prove mistaken, but the work of investigating is not therefore free. This is an artistically notable decision: giving neglected oral histories dignity does not require declaring them infallible. Tara keeps workers' compensation distinct from a stone's definitive legal significance.

Beyond the Embankment: The Ethical Weight of an Environmental Chain of Causes

Earth filled in on one side of the embankment protects a settlement from high water; on the other side, however, it raises the level of drainage from fields and homes and traps the water. This double consequence leaves the simple equation "an embankment was built, therefore there is safety" unproved. Hira judges the slope from shadows, but a shadow is not a measurement of the speed of water flow. Aditi will not decide to cut the embankment without wider examination. The narrator refuses to reduce security and environmental questions to the moral guilt of one community against another. Protecting a settlement and causing water damage elsewhere may be simultaneous effects. Here the mouth of the drainage channel, an old footpath, the outlet from the fields, and the place where boats land together form a connected waterscape.

A child draws a river line in the earth; the grandmother bends it with a hoe to show how a house might be saved. The scene creates narrative resonance: a river's line can be freely adjusted in play, while on actual ground it is a question of livelihood and economic survival. The game does

not, however, establish a real drainage route; the narrative itself reiterates the need for material measurement. In environmental narratology, it is useful to read space not as inert background but as an active system whose conditions change over time. An older copy shows a straight edge while local practice follows three turns. "Nothing shown" on a map is not the same as "nothing exists" on the ground.

The All-Season Capacity Certificate: Consent and the Event of Refusal

A committee member produces a prepared certificate declaring the route safe in every season for carts and boat-related equipment. Hira has manoeuvred an empty cart only halfway along the path. No test of peak monsoon conditions, boat loads, or pedestrian safety has been performed. He refuses to sign. The episode resembles Lalit's refusal in Chapter 41, but there is a difference specific to the object. Lalit would not certify the capacity of a wooden platform to bear heavy loads; Hira will not certify the universal all-season capacity of transport through the gate. In both cases, the reasoning refuses to declare comprehensive safety on the basis of incomplete inspection.

Urmila is not satisfied with a prohibition alone: she asks which route patients' linen will take and who will pay for the extra labour required to carry it by hand. Hira specifies the limits of pedestrian access; Aditi appoints a separate team to inspect an alternative route; and a temporary arrangement is made to carry essential linen in two portions around the safe outer bend. The gate is not opened and the "all-season" certificate is not accepted, but essential work is not simply abandoned. The characters' capacities emerge through this realistically intermediate outcome. An ethical response to a safety crisis is not prohibition alone: it also provides for the labour cost of limited alternatives.

Materials Bills, Local Occupational Names, and the Chapter's Threshold

Madhav Rauniyar provides chalk and a packet of paper for inspection but will not release two sacks of lime without a definite purpose. The price of two unused packets is deducted from the bill. This small commercial episode displays both the possibility of error in public expenditure and the environmental risk of spreading unnecessary material near the river. Procurement for the gate inspection is a different order from the earlier hospital purchases; the same retailer does not, without further evidence, establish a link in a crime.

An old wage list found with Shyam contains working names such as "Red Cap" and "Small Boat" instead of personal names. An assistant wants to call these false names and treat all receipts as suspicious; Tara distinguishes

occupational nicknames, personal names, and forged signatures. Naira requests the original register instead of making an accusation. This incident causally generates Chapter 48: the end of this section passes an unfinished line of reasoning forward rather than forgetting the gate and opening an unrelated new story.

Narrative time runs from the morning inspection to a notebook entry at night. The original old report and the grandmother's folk memory enter as remnants of an earlier period; there is no independent mythological time frame in this chapter. Focalisation shifts among Hira's embodied knowledge, Tara's local measurements, Aditi's official responsibility, and Urmila's pain at the obstruction of movement. The difference between a small leaf turning at the end and the actual load of a boat leaves the reader room for independent thought. A critical limitation is that nearly every character's instruction to "avoid excessive claims" is again heard in much the same polished register. Nevertheless, running water, the slope at the gate, sinking earth, and lost income prevent the scene from becoming merely an illustration of a philosophical rule.

Chapter 48 — Three Reasons for Disguise

Two Days' Wages for "Red Cap": The First Ethical Test of a Pseudonym

Shyam Mallik holds an old wage list. Opposite "Red Cap" are two days of work and an amount due, but the signature acknowledging payment is missing. The copy found in a former contractor's box is not the original register of names. An office assistant wants to display a photograph of the list on a public board so that people will recognise their names and come forward. Tara and Naira raise the risk of exposing private identities. Establishing who should receive unpaid wages and deciding to publish someone's true address for everyone to see are decisions governed by different rights. By its third passage, therefore, the narrator has established the mystery not as a puzzle for identifying a criminal but as a combined incompleteness of payment and security.

The list contains full names, working names, later additions in ink, and empty fields. Such material discrepancies admit several possibilities: historical correction, a clerical mistake, concealed identity, or deception. A reader may expect the old-fashioned solution to a mystery, but Naira chooses to "investigate first." This is narrative delay within the event structure: information becomes available while judgment is deferred. Delay is also an ethical achievement, since hasty publication of a single page might endanger workers. Still, it is reasonable to ask whether repeated postponements weaken the story's suspense or dramatic energy.

Nazir and Sumitra: Marks of Work, Personal Names, and Ownership of Materials

Nazir Sikligar displays repair slips for a fastening device used to tighten boat ropes, a chisel, and metal tools. The complete name of the customer's household is not on his public receipt; instead, it uses an occupational identifier such as "boatman." A municipal assistant starts to connect this to an earlier rumour about weapons. Hira fits the actual device to a rope to demonstrate the difference between the old looseness and the newly repaired grip. A sharp-edged shape alone cannot establish an object's purpose or an offence. Nazir's genuine economic difficulty is that if a day is consumed by official questioning, repairs remain unfinished and his earnings fall. The question of remuneration adds the direct economic cost of evidentiary investigation to the story.

Sumitra Kami has stamped her triangular mark onto a metal joint. It does not mean "concealing a name": it identifies the craftsmanship of a sample she made. She keeps the original drawing so that a future contractor cannot inspect the sample and appropriate credit for its design. The office records conditions for receiving and returning the sample. Here Sumitra wishes her name to be public, while another worker may wish to restrict personal identification for safety. It would be wrong to place both cases into the same category called "confidentiality." The right to decide how to be identified belongs to the particular person, and depositing a sample for inspection does not automatically transfer final design rights.

"Moti" in Pencil, a Protected Letter, and Two Payment Stamps

The wet original box in the storehouse is not pulled out without a conservation procedure. On a second copy found outside, "Moti" is pencilled beside "Red Cap"; it has not been established whether this denotes a person, a boat, or a later note. The paper's colour, handwriting, and provenance are recorded. In a separate letter, a woman claiming wages asks that the name of her home not be made public. There had previously been a commotion in which people searched for her, and she needs a safe place to stay with her child. Naira does not copy the letter's address. The work does more than preach an ethics of privacy: within the event, it actually stops a potentially dangerous act of writing.

A subsequent payment copy has different amounts beside "Red Cap" and "Moti" on the same date. But one bears the stamp "payment outstanding" and the other "advance issued." To call the same date and similar names proof of duplicate payment requires comparison of whether payment actually occurred, the persons to whom money was transferred, the original stamp register, and attendance at work. The narrator does not dismiss the possibility of fraud, but refuses to establish an offence from the

evidence presently available. Here the narratological examination of the subject of a claim, its proposition to be proved, and its supporting reason finds an appropriate critical use: two names and two amounts are directly available data, whereas receipt of two unlawful payments by a single person is a separate proposition that has not been proved.

Sairandhri in Viratanagara: An Actual Intertextual Scene from an Ancient Time

An independent ancient temporal setting opens in the fifteenth passage. In Viratanagara, Draupadi, working under the name Sairandhri, tells a maidservant that one must choose for oneself how much of one's identity to disclose to another person: if the prescribed period of concealment is broken, the family's safety may be threatened. This imagined scene should be regarded as an intertext composed by the novelist in modern language, not a direct quotation from a Mahabharata verse. The narrative connects the ancient protective disguise with the modern woman worker's confidential address. Draupadi and the present-day woman who refuses disclosure of her name are, however, neither the same individual nor in identical circumstances. Their historical periods, systems of authority, and risks differ.

This scene gives the title Virata Parva a particular narrative significance. In some earlier chapters, disguise remained only a structural analogy; here a change of historical time actually takes place within the story. Comparison must preserve the distance between these two temporal strands. Sairandhri's occupational name is a means of protection; Nazir's "boatman" is a working nickname; Sumitra's triangular mark constitutes evidence of professional credit; a name can also be altered through a writing error; and possible fraud needs separate evidence. These differences train the reader simultaneously to distrust the apparent certainty of external names and respect each individual's decisions about identity.

Three Reasons and Five Rules: The Literary Power and Limits of Classification

The chapter title points to three reasons: disguise for safety, a customary name associated with livelihood, and the possibility of deceit. Naira's register of five arrangements also includes a publicly chosen name and errors of language or script made by a clerk. Shyam asks why there are three reasons if there are five rules. Naira differentiates three broad concerns underlying a decision from five methods of checking and maintaining records. Classification does not take the place of events here; it creates a grammar for testing them. At the end, the child's drawing

labelled "Small Boat" repeats at a domestic scale the experience of keeping a person's name distinct from the name of a boat.

This classification also has a limitation. The experiences grouped within the "three reasons"—social self-naming, linguistic error, and occupational nicknames—overlap; Naira's own five rules separate them further. A critic should not treat this complex scheme as a final and exhaustive logical taxonomy. Its value is the practical regulation of an inquiry so that preventing false wage claims does not expose an endangered woman or an ordinary artisan. Public names versus internal reconciliation of payments is a problem requiring collective administrative structures. One sensitive recorder cannot supply the entire solution.

The Cost of an Incomplete Inquiry: A Connecting Thread for the Next Parva

A municipal member wishes to suspend all work at the gate until the original register is found. Hira distinguishes prohibiting unsafe load-bearing passage from essential maintenance within safe limits. Tara demands written conditions governing wages before the new inspection team arrives. The office grants partial approval, but old unpaid dues, safe examination of the original register, and final ownership of the sample remain unsettled. At the end of the chapter, Naira's third "request to see the original" results in a date being fixed for its receipt by the office. This is a real improvement in administrative timing, not an event in which the original document has already been placed in her hands.

The narrative runs linearly from Shyam's morning list to Naira's writing at night, interrupted by an independent ancient-time entry featuring Sairandhri in Viratanagara. An external third-person voice shifts the scenes, moving its attention among Shyam's helplessness, Tara's concern for wage justice, Naira's archival caution, and the artisans' embodied expertise. Here the mystery of "disguise" joins the novel's larger name-register structure. However, there is no proven connection between the gate's "Red Cap" list and the original sheet containing Sarita's twenty-seven names; Naira deliberately keeps the files separate. This care controls the reader's excessive appetite for conspiracy. The literary limitation remains that most characters are extraordinarily disciplined in their reasoning. Nazir's unfinished repair, Tara's delayed wages, and the drawing of a boat by Shyam's son introduce the human life that resists such uniformity.

Virata Parva / Aranya Kanda: Overall Critical Assessment of Chapters 37–48

The Narrative Departure: From Characters in Disguise to a Workshop of Evidence

Across the twelve chapters of the Virata Parva, the kitchen in Chapter 37 and Brihannala's class in Chapter 38 open questions of labour and self-identification by refashioning Mahabharata names. The weaver's rate sheet (39), the laundry register (40), Lalit's wooden ramp (41), Shakuntala's clay site (42), Meena's metal delivery note (43), and Harinarayan's tools (44) successively demonstrate unequal spheres of evidence in physical objects and written registers. In the last four chapters, labels on the shared vehicle's consignments (45–46), the measurement of the gate (47), and occupational nicknames (48) become so interconnected that one may be tempted to treat a common register as the solution to every crime. The novel makes its characters resist that temptation.

The structure matters not because each chapter introduces a separate occupation. At its strongest, an object changes a character's wishes and decisions. Yusuf forgoes the chance of double payment and suspends a sale; Urmila records extra hours of walking and handling goods alongside the vehicle's delay; Hira refuses an "all-season" safety certificate while proposing limited alternative access; Naira protects the address of an endangered woman. These are events, not merely ethical propositions. But the repeated practice of "entering everything under separate headings" creates planned uniformity across scenes involving more than eight artisans. The desires and internal conflicts of living characters interrupt the repetition. Especially valuable are the disagreement between Yusuf and his son over an inherited profession and the different hopes Shakuntala and her granddaughter hold for the future.

Not a Single Narrative Time, but the Cost of Several Kinds of Time

Each of the four newer chapters chiefly passes through one day, from morning to noon, evening, and night. Yet labour time is not uniform: Yusuf waits with his trade suspended; Mahendra loses customers; Urmila urgently needs to deliver hospital linen; artisans spend otherwise productive hours at inspections; and Sairandhri inhabits the ancient time of concealment. Narrative movement slows during discussions of documents and testimony, but accelerates in brief scenes involving children, the use of tools, and a wheel slipping at the gate. "Time" in this novel is therefore not chronology alone; it is also a measure of wages owed, risks endured, and consent withheld or granted.

The explicitly mythological scenes occur earlier in the Ballava–Brihannala episodes and at the end in the Sairandhri scene. Chapters 45–47 contain no independent scene populated by mythological figures; there the Virata motif of "disguise" functions structurally. Without this distinction, a map of seven kandas and eighteen parvas would become a mechanical equivalence imposed on the text from outside. The Aranya Kanda's displacement, insecure access, and uncertain rights combine with the Virata Parva's perspective on concealment to form a layered experience, but not a scene-by-scene retelling of the Ramayana.

Narratology, Indian Poetics, and Videha Parallel History

In Chapters 45–48 the reader encounters numerous unproven inferences: from a stamp to a maker; from a vehicle number to theft; from "white material" to medical cleaning powder; from the width between iron posts to a safe route in every season; from a nickname to fraud; and from two amounts to duplicate payment. Each requires intermediate evidence or examination of an alternative possibility. From this viewpoint, critical attention to the subject of inference, its reason, its proposition to be established, and its qualifying conditions supplies a useful discipline. But contemporary contracts, patient confidentiality, and engineering safety are not exact instances quoted directly from a classical Nyaya treatise. The philosophical intention of the Tattvachintamani must remain distinct from the novel's social applications.

From the viewpoint of Indian poetics, the suggestive resonance of names is extensive. Stamps, occupational aliases, working nicknames, artisans' marks on tools, and the names children give to boats are not merely social signs; they define the limits of a person's credit, security, memory, claims, and dues. Yusuf's silent loom, the clean cotton Rahim gives his daughter, the slow turning of a leaf, and the boat drawn by Shyam's son soften the rigour of the analysis as perceptible images. Economic uncertainty persists between compassion and enthusiasm; the narrative does not seek an uncomplicated emotional resolution. The Videha Parallel History perspective becomes useful when people in small occupations serve as primary sources of their own time, self-designation, and microeconomies, rather than appearing merely as names in a catalogue of folk culture.

Overall Achievement and Outstanding Critical Questions

An important achievement of the Virata Parva is that it treats occupational craft knowledge as an aid to correcting administrative practice while respecting the limits of that knowledge. A potter's examination of clay is not an engineering load test; a boatman's measuring pole is not an absolute certificate of embankment safety; a copy of a record is not the original document; recognition of labour does not produce a public list of suspected criminals. This discipline has ethical importance for individual autonomy, wages, children's privacy, and environmental risks.

Nevertheless, criticism must leave three contrary questions open. First, how many characters truly receive different decisions, errors, voices, and methods of resistance, and how often does the author's evidentiary ethics speak in the same manner through their mouths? Second, do repeated incomplete administrative outcomes preserve the plot's realism, or do they slow its narrative momentum excessively? Third, although artisans' experience is recognised as a source of knowledge, final legal authority remains with institutions: to what extent does the story challenge this inequality, and to what extent does it take it for granted? These three tests should be carried into the following Udyoga Parva, with its questions of cooperation and treaties.

Udyoga Parva / Kishkindha Kanda

Chapter 49 — The Price of Cooperation

The Altered Sound of the Opening: Bamboo Bark Instead of the Hammer

In the chapter's first passage, the expected sound of a hammer near the gate is displaced by the sound of bamboo bark being stripped. The alteration is unostentatious yet narratively meaningful. Amid unfinished construction and suspended certification, the immediate task is not to build a permanent bridge but to identify a dangerous place. Shyam Mallik's bamboo had been intended as a boat pole for a customer; the municipality's invitation takes working time away from his household's earnings. The official message suspending routine measurement until the original wage register is found records attendance time but not the amount due. The opening conflict, therefore, is not "public good versus private self-interest" but whose household must bear the cost of that good. The narrator supplies details of objects, time, and debt before presenting the moral disagreement. Through that sequence, the reader is given the economic grounds of the worker's decision.

The municipality's form for "voluntary local cooperation" contains a line making samples and information available for "public use." Tara objects to its possible transfer of ownership. Aditi acknowledges that it is an old form introduced for safety inspection, not to change ownership of the drawing. Yet Tara examines the effect of the signed wording rather than the good intentions of a particular person. The centre of narration moves from "what Aditi thinks" to "what rights will follow from the signature on the page." This is an important distinction in a modern documentary narrative. Shyam's small, three-knotted bamboo model demonstrates how a wheel can slip; it is not a load-bearing bridge. His refusal to let the assistant take away the model is an act of resistance, but it also declares the limits of the model's technical authority.

Register of Direct Events and Resulting Conditions

Initial situation: the municipality summons local people to the dangerous gate without clearly specifying the work or wages. First obstruction: an attempt is made to purchase Parvati Tanti's weaving and Pavitra Patwa's plaiting under the single description "cloth strips," which could erase the labour of separate households in one account entry. Second obstruction: Shyam's ancestral drainage line is in danger of becoming the object of an official copy, although family memory is not conclusive evidence of a

technical plan. Third change: Tara constructs four columns—object, artisan, time and price, and limits of use. Aditi authorises separate temporary work orders in the individual names, with advances from a restricted emergency allocation. Outcome: Parvati and Pavitra receive notifications that money has reached their accounts; Shyam receives confirmation of a transfer, but receipt still requires checking; Tara's first outstanding payment remains unresolved. Temporary red-and-yellow warning strips are placed on the ground. Neither permanent repairs nor load-bearing certification follow.

This register has an important limit. Aditi's emergency authority is restricted: she does not approve the complete drainage contract, and she seeks separate administrative authorisation for additional measurements. Thus even "the price of cooperation has been paid" is not wholly true. Some advances have arrived, one transfer remains to be checked, earlier arrears remain, and the procedure for a permanent register of attribution is unfinished. This kind of partial resolution can be measured against the condition of the characters; it is not merely asserted by the author.

The Multiplicity of Labour, the Right to a Name, and Mutual Dependence

Parvati's three lengths of cloth and Pavitra's eight plaited strips serve the same safety arrangement, but their manufacture is not the same. Recording "weaving" and "plaiting" on separate slips develops an economic argument out of the material detail of narrative action. Parvati's remark—that separate payment does not mean separation—becomes a critical definition of cooperation. Collective usefulness and individual attribution are not enemies. Hira's inspection of the water route, Shyam's bamboo model, and Tara's local measurements are similarly distinct kinds of work. Putting all the names on one form does not, by itself, produce technical certification.

The principal focal centres follow Tara's and Shyam's practical concerns, while Parvati, Pavitra, Hira, and Aditi speak from their different economic and administrative limits. Through external presentation, the narrator brings Shyam's anger at losing a customer, the limits of Aditi's authority, and the landholding representative's disagreement into a single social scene. In this sense, claims of "polyphony" require care: there are multiple points of view, but whether every character develops an autonomous ideological idiom cannot be decided without comparing the entire parva.

Kishkindha's Earlier Story: Sugriva's Fear and the Limits of a Promise

The ancient temporal strand enters in passages 12–13. On Rishyamuka, Sugriva initially sees Rama and Lakshmana as possible enemies; Hanuman

acts as an intermediary who listens. Rama's search and Sugriva's exile are not the same problem, only possible grounds for alliance. Before the witness of fire or any final pledge of fidelity, both sides want their needs and limits made clear. This scene is not a mechanical reflection of Chapter 49's local contract. Its significant parallel lies in the conditions of reaching an agreement between parties of unequal power. Ancient politics and modern labour administration belong to different historical levels; a mythological decision must not be taken as literal proof of contemporary municipal regulations.

The Regime of Evidence, Language, and Impartial Evaluation

From a narratological perspective, the old bamboo line is a subject for investigation informed by memory, not established proof of a land right or technical drawing. A temporary warning indicates danger, not a legal change of boundary. An "instruction to transfer" does not amount to direct confirmation that funds have reached the beneficiary's bank. Naira prevents an attempt to derive a child-abduction accusation from "Little Boat," a nickname in the old wage register. A claim about one subject cannot establish an unrelated proposition merely because both appear beside a document. Registers, receipts, payments, and objections constitute different kinds of knowledge.

In terms of Indian poetics, the working sound of bamboo bark, the yellow-and-red warning strip, and the four square spaces Shyam draws for his son introduce the possibility of educating the next generation of readers. The child understands the colours of the safety markers as the colours of a game; Parvati explains their purpose. At this point the scene moves beyond its utilitarian message and becomes an act of correcting linguistic meaning.

One critical limitation is that numerous characters devise suitable classifications for forms almost at the same instant. This narrative efficiency can abbreviate the actual exhaustion of social negotiation. Nevertheless, Shyam's lost customer, his family's debt, and the persistence of old arrears partly resist the convenient resolution. The preservation of three dissenting parties' names in the final passage is evidence of an open conflict rather than a simplified victory.

Chapter 50 — Sugriva's Fear

The Unanticipated Result of a Safety Measure: The Strip Was Placed, the Route Changed

On the day after Chapter 49's temporary warning, the narrative opens with the dew-soaked strip at the gate and Uma Rajdhob's three sheets. In

the previous chapter a danger had been marked; now people take another, unsafe footpath after the marking. Tara explains that the direction of movement has changed, not that the danger has disappeared. This direct causal relation carries the plot of the Udyoga Parva to another level: the unintended consequences of a public order. The landholding representative's apprehension about the path through the fields is not merely reactionary obstinacy; it expresses the fear that a provisional mark may become a permanent determination of rights. Aditi separates the duration of technical measures from their legal consequences.

The world of laundry labour offers a new vantage on this crisis. Uma fears losing three customers to other washerfolk; there is the possibility of using shared shade and the pressure of a unilateral rate imposed by the inn. These are economic circumstances directly linked to water safety at the gate. Her independence depends on the physical place where clothes can be dried. Urmila offers to share her safe platform, but does not claim control of Uma's customers or independent bargaining. The distinction between cooperation and subordination is the semantic centre of this episode.

Uma, Urmila, and Shanti: Three Actual Costs of Cooperation

Uma sets three conditions: the washing from each household must carry a separate serial number; every artisan's payment must be independent; and the costs of common shade, water, and access must be itemised separately. Urmila adds a fourth issue, the cost of testing unsafe water. The inn's representative proposes placing all washing under one name and presses for half the rate. Despite the cost of educating her daughter, Uma rejects the terms. The result is not a risk-free triumph of courage: the inn's work goes to a competing washer. The price of resistance is thus entered into the narrative with a named loss. The possibility remains of a provisional timetable for sharing shade with Urmila; no hospital contract, private customers, or personal wages are transferred.

Shanti Bari makes materials for weddings. Her wet chest, ceremonial gateway, bark, and cotton thread make visible the materials and time embodied in her products. She demands half the cost in advance from a family requesting goods without payment, with the remainder due on delivery. For families unable to pay, she suggests a separate voluntary assistance fund. One family deposits rent for a shared ceremonial gateway against a receipt; not every proposal is accepted. Separating “gift” from “wages” parallels Uma and Urmila's separation of common facilities from private clients. Nevertheless, the commercial objects, risks, and outcomes of the two incidents are different.

Phulo Chaurasia's old family paper bearing the name “Khiroi” opens a third and distinctive crisis of evidence. The paper contains the name and two old expense figures, but cannot by itself establish the present drainage

benefit, a survey of the land, or a connection with the current gate. Phulo objects to an increased charge based upon the supposed claim. The landholding representative agrees to receive a written objection, not to reverse the entire decision on expenses. At the chapter's close Tara explicitly distinguishes Uma's recorded loss, Shanti's single receipt, and Phulo's hearing: they are not the same achievement. This distinction offers the central ground of critical evaluation.

Sugriva in the Dual-Time Narrative: Admitting Fear, Deferring Judgment

The ancient Kishkindha scene occupies passages 17–20. Afraid that Rama and Lakshmana may be Bali's emissaries, Sugriva tests their power. The cave entrance, blood, an inference about his brother's death, and Bali's anger are narrated by Sugriva as memories of his side of the dispute. The narrator does not stamp those memories as conclusive judicial truth. Alongside recovering the kingdom, Sugriva asks about the rights of people who would remain under a possible new government. His particular question—when two brothers offer opposing accounts, whose word will Rama's arrow believe?—casts doubt on the balance of power within "friendship."

The relation between this scene and Uma's resistance is indirect: can the oral assurance of a powerful helper suffice in an alliance with a weaker petitioner? One setting involves royal authority and the fear of death, the other dependence upon customers and threats to a livelihood. Treating them as identical would erase their social differences. Comparing the conditions of consent and the right to articulate fear, however, is fruitful. Rama's statement does not yet settle the conflict, so Sugriva's doubt remains part of the plot.

Time, Focalisation, and the Stratification of Evidence

The chapter moves from hanging sheets in the morning, through the shared discussion at noon, to a lost customer in the evening and the measurement ledger at night. Within that trajectory the separate temporal line of ancient Kishkindha enters. This transition makes an impasse in the modern narrative thinkable through an epic alternative, but the ancient episode does not cause the modern event. Narration chiefly uses external description, granting limited interior access to Uma's financial insecurity, Tara's scrutiny of forms, and Sugriva's fear. The reader gradually learns the experiences of distinct characters; no omniscient administrative "final finding" is supplied.

In the narrative's distinctions, the warning board marks the limit of a direct risk; it is not a permanent judicial declaration of land rights. The historical writing containing "Khiroi" does not prove a current drainage

benefit. The nickname "Little Boat" is not evidence of a person's identity or child abduction. A notice referring to the "joint transfer" of laundry does not establish that a contract was in fact transferred. Naira keeps the publicly relevant extract of the family paper separate from its private debt details. This contextual delimitation of evidence is put to work in the story, rather than confined to philosophical vocabulary.

Literary Achievement and Counterargument

The serial numbers from Uma's own register on the three sheets, Shanti's wet wedding chest, the folded Khiroi paper carried by Phulo, and the landholder's yellow marker give history, livelihood, and public safety different material forms. Uma's daughter reads the accounts, but her mother does not compel her to enter the washing trade. That fine scene of intergenerational rights signals the valuable distinction between the dignity of labour and an obligation to inherit an occupation. Giving Shanti's daughter a choice of colours for the ceremonial gateway does not extinguish the worker's entitlement to be paid.

A limitation remains: certain formal objections turn into well-ordered documents from one meeting to the next with greater smoothness than the long failures of real social bargaining would suggest. Yet the actual loss of the inn's work and the unresolved expenditure claimed against Phulo preserve the story from this simplification. The achievement of "Sugriva's Fear" lies in presenting fear neither as a moral fault nor as final truth. Fear must be heard; the question whose evidence will determine the judgment remains unanswered.

Chapter 51 — Tara's Reckoning

Three Cords, Three Facts: The Initial Refusal to Combine Measurements

At the chapter's opening Tara Binaut measures the same gate three ways: the distance between the posts, the strip along which people walk, and the ground washed away in the rains. Her observation—"If you add all three into one number, a person will fall, not the paper"—does not reject numbers; it rejects inappropriate aggregation. Reducing shape, use, and risk to a single measure creates confusion. Tara does not claim that her expertise replaces that of the engineer Aditi. She wants to sign her own name to responsibility for what she has seen and heard locally. Within that difference, the novel presents a concrete model for democratising knowledge: the value of local experience can be acknowledged without abolishing technical qualifications.

The municipality's slip credits only office assistants with the local suggestions. Tara does not tear it up; she marks it with a red-pencil question mark. This small action is a concealed emblem of verification: she opposes manipulation of the archive without destroying original evidence. Meanwhile Ruchi Dharikar brings a bamboo warning model made with a double turn. The office's stamp of its own invention has been placed on work that resembles her weave. Showing a photograph and possessing the right to reproduce the design are not the same. Aditi stops the printing of the form, undertakes to check whether photography was authorised, and requires separate permissions for public display and commercial copying. This initiates an inquiry, not a final judicial finding on ownership of the design.

Ruchi's daughter Chhabili raises questions about new colours and patterns. Her mother grants the child the right to learn, while cautioning that changing a colour does not automatically transfer credit for a pre-existing design. Rather than imprisoning the next generation's innovations in a monopoly of inherited craft, the scene argues for creative discipline. There is certainly a dispute over the rights attached to the design; the distinctive achievement of the episode lies, however, in its two-way education in productive imagination and recognition of labour.

Saqib's Two Ledgers and the Incomplete Receipt: The Proper Extent of Doubt

Saqib Abdal's receipts for public contributions to cleaning the drainage channel are separate from his private transportation ledger. The appearance of the same name in both accounts proves neither that the sum is the same nor that its purpose is identical. On finding an incomplete receipt under "food," a representative suggests that the entire collected fund has been stolen. Tara draws the proper boundary: the evidence for one expenditure line is incomplete; the embezzlement of the entire public fund does not follow. Saqib admits that he took no written receipt. An old materials page at the shop mentions food items, but does not adequately establish the date of payment. His decision is not to fabricate a paper but to write "verification pending." This admission becomes a scene of moral development: the character is declared neither innocent nor guilty.

The incident offers a useful narrative examination of the relation between what is to be proved and its alleged reason (sādhya and hetu). The absence of a record for one expense cannot serve as the reason establishing the appropriation of an entire public collection when the required invariable connection has not been demonstrated. Nevertheless, an unproved sweeping accusation does not exonerate the local error: the missing receipt remains a legitimate matter for inquiry. Saqib does not open his family's complete private transport ledger to the public. Naira agrees to limited

inspection of entries connected with public funds. This proposes a working settlement between privacy and accountability, not the final outcome of a completed investigation.

The recurrence of the nickname "Little Boat" connects an older plot strand to the current dispute about contributions. Naira separates a person's nickname from the roles of donor and carrier of goods. The identical word treated as a "name" cannot establish personal identity; dates, original payment records, and context are needed. The rumour of a missing child is once again kept apart from this register. The novel therefore avoids manufacturing a cheap "major revelation" out of every possible offence, even as it sustains the reader's curiosity.

Tara and Bali in the Ancient Strand: The Voice of Counsel, the Warning Unheeded

Chapter 51 has explicitly dual-temporal entries in passages 14–18 and again in 28–30. The ancient Tara explains to Bali a possible reason for Sugriva's new confidence: assistance from Rama and Lakshmana may change the balance of power. Her concern for Angada, the peace of the kingdom, and her husband's safety are three interests that do not coincide; her speech articulates their conflict. Bali does not heed her advice. The truth of counsel does not win an immediate victory in the story: Bali goes to battle and falls to an arrow. Afterward Tara holds grief and anger together and insists that Angada's questions of justice be heard.

The title "Tara's Reckoning" establishes a visible relation between the modern Tara Binaut and the ancient Tara, yet these are two distinct personalities belonging to two temporal strands. Modern Tara calculates measuring cords, public funds, and hearing rights; ancient Tara reckons the price of possible battle, the trust of households, and her son's future. Their similarity does not lie in the superficial proposition that "women are always farsighted," but in the intellectual practice of seeing multiple interests together in uncertainty. The difference is equally meaningful. Modern Tara succeeds in getting her slip corrected; ancient Tara's counsel does not change Bali's decision. This failure reveals the distance between possessing knowledge and controlling decisions.

Upon Bali's death the ancient Tara does not congratulate herself by saying, "I told you so." This arrangement preserves the legitimacy of grief: compassion and political discrimination inhabit the same scene. Angada questions both the cause of his father's death and his place under the new king. Tara does not silence him. Such a rewriting of an ancient event may be read in conjunction with the novel's modern principles for hearings. It would, however, be a methodological mistake to treat it as literal proof of the original Ramayana or as a historical report.

The Sequence of Events and Outcomes: Ethical Inequalities in Narration

The causal register of modern scenes runs as follows: (a) objections to inconsistent measurements and anonymous official credit for local work; (b) stopping the proposed copying of Ruchi's model; (c) a limited inquiry into the incomplete "food" receipt in Saqib's ledger; (d) separate objections regarding Phulo's field and the landholder's vehicle route; (e) a consultative letter stating conditions for subsequent payment; and (f) Ruchi's restricted consent for two weeks of temporary safety testing. In the resulting conditions, Phulo obtains a hearing date; the landholder's objection is recorded with its date; Ruchi does not sign a large production order; Saqib leaves verification of the food expense pending. The questions of technical certification also remain open.

These outcomes are achievements of different sizes. Halting printing and securing approval for limited testing are immediately useful interventions; supplementary payments and inadequate contribution records require longer inquiries; the calculation of benefit or loss from land is still incomplete. Criticism would destroy the reader's sense of the events' credibility by grouping all of them under the formula "justice has been established." The narrator has a final ledger record the principle that whoever's interests are being calculated has the right to be heard, and leaves room for the voice of another young person. That vacant place prepares the dramatic entrance in the next chapter; it is not a predetermined epilogue.

Language, Craft, Achievement, and Limitation

The three uses of a measuring cord, the red-pencil question mark, the basket's double turn, the blank line on the food receipt, and the reserved space for a hearing are distinct visible objects embodying philosophical differences between forms of evidence. The domestic conversation between Tara and Shyam turns public labour rates back toward the question of unpaid work at home: in whose ledger should the care of one's own household be counted? This is valuable self-criticism, because transforming every kind of labour into a government bill is not a complete remedy for ethical inequality.

A formal limitation of this chapter must also be noted. The author repeatedly has characters speak of "separate kinds of work," "separate kinds of evidence," and "separate rights." Even while giving analytical precision, this can create an undesirable similarity among the characters' sentence structures. Yet ancient Tara's inability to control Bali's decision, Saqib's incomplete receipt, and Ruchi's rejection of the large contract yield

genuinely open consequences. They interrupt the apparent uniformity of a wholly successful ethical scheme.

Chapter 52 — Angada's Tomorrow

Home, Stage, and School: Different Lives Within the Name “Nomad”

At dawn in Chapter 52, Nandu Nat is dismantling the bamboo supports of a stage when his daughter Jhilmil asks where the shade for studying will be. The same bamboo joins three dimensions of their lives: the labour of performance, temporary shelter, and the practice of schooling. A municipal red-chalk notice orders them to “clear the route,” but specifies neither distance nor period nor authorisation. Gauri Kapariya objects with a wet tarpaulin and an old repair receipt. Her words—“We move, but we are not air”—provide a material response to the treatment of itinerant life as a formless exile. The receipt is not proof of land ownership, but it testifies to the family's possessions, expenditures, and labour.

Aditi clarifies that a risk assessment has been requested for the narrow section and that she has issued no written order for immediate clearance of the entire open ground. Gauri agrees to leave the dangerous section, but demands a safe alternative edge and written reasons. This is not a simple opposition between “safety” and “rights.” Gauri does not deny the risk; she resists broad, unsubstantiated eviction in the name of that risk. The danger that a temporary warning from the preceding chapter could be extended into something far more sweeping provides the episode's causal background.

Reva Gulguliya, Janki's troupe, and Gauri's group are not interchangeable representatives of an undifferentiated “nomadic community.” Continuity of schooling for Reva's son Jatan, the health of elderly Saryu in Janki's troupe, and the shelter of Gauri's family present different constraints. The small working group includes delegates chosen by the groups, a representative for individual petitions, and local residents. The groups' entire itineraries will not appear on a public map; only disputed safe routes and necessary contact details are to be recorded. Here the perspective of Videha Parallel History becomes useful: the objects, voices, and permissions of particular people suppressed under the collective policy label “nomad” become visible again.

Jhilmil's Time: Not Abandoning Art, but Reducing Night Work

A performance notice for the fish-and-makhana labour fair would require children to be present throughout the evening and proposes to halve the troupe's wages. Nandu needs money for rent and notebooks; Maina and Jhilmil have the next morning's school examination in mind. The girl

herself says that she does not want to abandon drumming and song, but wants to go to school first and sing when she chooses. It would be wrong to reduce the decision to a cheap conflict between a child's wishes and a parent's greed. Nandu's economic constraint is real, and so is the child's autonomy over her time.

Meera Mandal of the school shows the attendance of the travelling classroom, but does not mistake it for proof of formal enrolment. Madhu from the ghat committee proposes a potentially safe stage for two hours; Aditi insists on a separate inspection of the heavy platform and electrical wiring. The organiser's expected audience and payment shrink. Nandu records two hours of work, bamboo hire, and drum repair as separate items. Jhilmil stipulates for herself that she will take part in the first song and return on time. A week-long conditional permit is only proposed: no permanent site for performances has been approved. Nandu's diminished earnings are the actual cost of preserving schooling and autonomy. At the end Maina says explicitly that they will not keep their daughter onstage all night to pay for books; if necessary, they will seek other work.

The words “equal” and “unequal” in Jhilmil's textbook and her line on the last page—“I shall learn songs as well as accounts”—are not educational abstractions but linguistic echoes of a real struggle to divide time. The school is not inherently an institution hostile to performance; with appropriate conditions, both art and education could survive. Yet the provisional arrangement for the programme does not resolve the child's formal enrolment. The gap between the chapter's outward success and its persisting crisis is clear.

Sajid's Camera: Permission, the Market, and an Incomplete Digital Contract

A young man proposes incorporating Sajid Nat's old performance footage in municipal publicity, including children's faces. Those old images have circulated in the market, but circulation does not establish agreement to perpetual commercial exploitation. Sajid remembers that an excerpt of his performance had once been used in a false context in connection with the search for Mithun. He separates current public-safety publicity, artistic work, and children's privacy. Instead of handing over the “original file,” he asks that the purpose, period, and limits of use be written down.

The publicity representative offers a single lump-sum payment, in return for unlimited redistribution rights. Sajid rejects it and proposes two alternatives: restricted publicity excerpts with each performer's permission, or a new recording for a fixed fee. Children's rehearsal files, the old footage used out of context, and the original recording remain outside the current bargain. The representative threatens simply to record with his phone. Sajid explains that an audience member's informed consent and a

performer's rights over performance have different foundations. Jhilmil asks whether a shot of her hands on the drum would be possible; the camera is not turned on at that moment. What has been established is not the sweeping claim that "the child's picture is safe," but the postponement of one particular shoot and the incomplete state of the contract.

The narrative importance of new communications media lies in their double speed: pictures can become public immediately, while justifiable consent is slower, specific to parties, and limited in time. Naira's final decision not to use the old rumour of Mithun's disappearance to declare a fresh accusation in this performance dispute demonstrates a recurring ethical discipline concerning evidence.

Angada's Tomorrow: The Right to Question Instead of an Inherited Obligation

Ancient Kishkindha appears in passages 11–15 and 28–29 of Chapter 52. After Bali's death, Angada asks his mother Tara how friendship with the man who killed his father can protect him. Tara does not turn grief, a change of rulers, and a child's life into a single story. The underlying principle is clear: being someone's son is not to inherit his fault; it is a relationship of remembrance. Although Hanuman assists Sugriva, he asks that Angada's questions be heard. Angada's first demand is not the royal title for himself, but food for the households of the soldiers who fought for Bali. Sugriva promises a place for him to learn the work of kingship; Angada does not want this treated as a compulsory test of dynastic loyalty. Hanuman responds respectfully to the boy's desire to learn a messenger's work.

Later Angada rejects a permanent "enemy" label for the soldiers of the defeated side. Sugriva promises to count and assist the injured households. A promise is not evidence that distribution has already taken place; Angada's question becomes a test of the kingdom's future policies. The ancient grief scene does not transform Gauri's modern family or Nandu's daughter into the "modern reincarnation" of a mythological character. The sound basis of comparison is that a less powerful child or displaced group must not be silenced by inheritance, state power, or economic necessity. Angada moving his hand away from the mace and Jhilmil holding her book both question the apparent inevitability of violence or inherited labour, while preserving their distinct times and settings.

A Five-Layer Register of Events: The Proper Limits of Resolution

(1) Gauri, Tara, and Aditi challenge the indeterminate order marked in red. There is agreement not to spend the night on the dangerous track, but the grounds for an order evicting everyone remain uncertain. (2) Nandu, Maina, and Jhilmil choose a shorter performance in favour of school

hours, at the cost of expected income. (3) Sajid rejects unrestricted digital use and submits limited alternatives; a final video contract remains outstanding. (4) Reva, Janki, Gauri, Champa, and local members set out the different needs of temporary shelters. They receive acknowledgement of an inspection for the following morning, but an alternative open space has not been technically certified safe. (5) That night two of Gauri's families move away from the dangerous track to a safer edge; Nandu agrees to await written permission before erecting the performance bamboo; Naira preserves the three distinct work agreements in separate envelopes.

The final three envelopes constitute the ethical structure of the plot: stage-working hours, the incomplete draft of digital rights, and objections regarding temporary shelter. Combining these documents into one would resolve none of the actual problems. Gauri's tarpaulin receipt is not proof of ownership; Meera Mandal's attendance record is not formal school enrolment; the proposed week-long programme permit is not a permanent stage; and a family's temporary move is not rehabilitation. Such distinctions keep the reader's expectations in proportion to the events.

Focalisation, Compassion, and Critical Objection

The chapter progresses through communal action from morning until night, interrupted by Angada's ancient period of grief. The modern focal centre moves among Nandu's calculation of livelihood, Jhilmil's study hours, Gauri's shelter, and the limits Sajid places upon his camera. Compassion arises not merely from describing suffering families but from displaying their power to refuse and their divergent internal opinions. Gauri, who says "We move, but we are not air," does not promise to renounce itinerant life: she asks for a safe route and a hearing. Jhilmil chooses education without surrendering her art. Angada remembers his father while questioning the new regime. Their voices do not serve identical ends, but each insists on a corresponding kind of autonomous right.

A formal limitation remains: the meetings repeatedly employ ideal procedural language—limited permission, separate receipts, distinct purposes. In places this framework can suppress the social differences in the characters' idioms. To counter that risk the narrative presents Nandu's reduced income, Gauri's uncertain second night, Sajid's rejected offer, and Angada's continuing grief. The final beat of the drum is a "beginning," not an order; the resulting condition stays open.

Udyoga Parva / Kishkindha Kanda: Combined Criticism of Chapters 49–52

A Real Change in Narrative Movement

In the Virata Parva the predominant struggle was to protect artisans' objects, credit, and occupational identities. The first four chapters of the Udyoga Parva transform that protection into questions about collective agreements and potentially unequal alliances. Chapter 49's limited emergency order changes how people move in Chapter 50; the distribution of benefit and loss in Chapter 50 becomes Tara's three-part measurement and the right to a hearing in Chapter 51; the empty place left for a young voice in Chapter 51 becomes visible in Angada's and Jhilmil's own questions in Chapter 52. These are not simply four independent introductions to occupations; the chapters possess a clear causal continuity.

Narrative Time, the Other Temporal Strand, and Centred Consciousness

All four modern chapters move through compressed cycles of dawn, noon, evening, and night. Ancient scenes appear explicitly in Chapter 49, in Chapter 50 (passages 17–20), Chapter 51 (14–18 and 28–30), and Chapter 52 (11–15 and 28–29). Epic time offers ways of "interpreting" the modern scene, but is not its physical cause. Sugriva's uncertain friendship, ancient Tara's unheeded warning, and Angada's questions form three temporal phases of agreement, decision, and accountability. There is no textual basis for declaring the local Tara Binaut a reincarnation of ancient Tara. The narrator layers different characters' sentiments, the temporal histories of objects, and the limits of written documents. This is a multicentred narration, but not an unrestricted distribution of omniscient truth across both periods.

Narratology, the Videha Perspective, and Indian Poetics

This sequence presents several possible fallacies of inference: treating a safety marker as permanent ownership; an old place name as evidence of the current area benefiting from a project; the absence of one expense entry as theft of an entire collection; a photograph as a complete transfer of rights in craftsmanship; a temporary application as a permanent eviction order; and school attendance as formal enrolment. The characters test the range of the connections alleged between these propositions. Such discipline in establishing what can be known becomes practical knowledge of life inside literature, not decoration with philosophical labels. At the level of poetics, the coloured strip, bark, sheet, measuring cord, mace, drum, and three envelopes create many possibilities of indirect designation

and suggestive resonance (lakṣaṇā and dhvani): safety, memory, ownership, and a future not yet foreclosed. The scenes' compassion and dissent arise from the recurrence of objects, not only from prescriptive speeches.

From the standpoint of Videha Parallel History, artisans' names, reduced wages, safe contact details for itinerant families, children's school hours, women's credit for craftwork, and incomplete pages of barely visible contributions preserve experience omitted from governmental summaries. Yet "parallel" does not mean declaring every state record false. Aditi's limited technical permissions and Naira's preservation of evidence remain necessary to the story. Criticism must understand the intricacy of both cooperation and opposition.

Achievements, Partial Failures, and Further Inquiry

The principal achievement of these chapters is that the ethics of cooperation becomes the concrete question of whose labour, risk, voice, and decision are at stake. Their limitations include an excessive similarity in administrative and procedural speech, the repeated formation of registers with three or four categories, and the comparatively restricted psychology of some opposing representatives. Further inquiry from contrary perspectives is needed. How much of the landholding representative's fear expresses legitimate economic insecurity, and how much expresses privilege? At what point could a claim to local ownership prevent collective sharing of knowledge? What becomes of Jhilmil's formal schooling after recognition of her right to study? The analysis suggests questions for subsequent chapters; only the original narrative can provide the answers. At the boundary of Chapters 49–52 the first alliance is neither wholly successful nor defeated: people are gaining the opportunity to record their conditions, but a durable decision concerning the public water interest remains outstanding.

Chapter 53 — Ruhani's Key

A Key Is an Instrument, Not Proof of Ownership

The chapter opens with a rusted lock and two keys that resemble each other. The gate key and the storeroom key are objects with different uses; treating either as a universal authorisation can cause an accident. Ruhani makes it clear at the outset that the work of opening a door does not make her the building's owner. From this first scene begins a criticism of power within a shelter. When skill and protective responsibilities are concentrated in one person, both that person's exhaustion and other residents' dependence increase. Repeatedly asking for "the orders of the

house" is a language that invites the exercise of power, but the character herself rejects such undeclared leadership.

The key's first meaning is not merely material. The story risks grouping a person's private room, another's protection from fire and water, access to the kitchen, and relief details under the single term "shelter." Similar objects do not imply identical rights. In terms of the narrative distinction between the subject of an inference and what is to be proved, "Ruhani has the gate key" is an observed fact; "Ruhani may decide on the private lives of all residents" is an unproved conclusion without another supporting reason. Instead of personal animosity, the narrative uses agreements with defined limits to prevent that leap.

Different Forms of Women's Decisions: Champa and Manjari

Champa's mother requires medicine and care, but the older woman herself decides to go to her sister's house. Champa wants two days for a river journey. Ruhani's question—"Has your mother agreed?"—has its own ethical weight. Caring for a mother is not the same as making the daughter her permanent servant. The older woman's prescription may contain necessary details for family medical assistance, but it is not an instrument for publicly monitoring Champa's private travels. Here rest is made an ordinary right of self-determination rather than a reward for eliciting compassion. A brief leave for a tired carer becomes an event in the story because it really changes the shelter's established relations of dependence.

Manjari's episode presents a larger uncertainty surrounding rights. After eight months in the shelter, she is considering renting a house with a friend. She holds an old five-hundred-rupee note, a rent slip, and her sewing basket. She asks not for permission to decide but for recognition of her right to decide. Rukhsana, on the other hand, fears that the shelter's grant will decrease when the number of residents falls. The novel does not evade the difficulty. When an institution develops an interest in maintaining the number of dependants in the name of providing support, the possibility of captivity begins to grow within its benevolence. Ruhani agrees to examine the terms of the assistance letter, but refuses to make Manjari's life a "ration number."

The new house's water charge was not in writing. Manjari asks the landlord directly and has it entered on the rental slip. Her advance payment has not been completely reduced, but responsibility for water is clarified and her departure is fixed for Monday. She prevents her former bed from being reassigned immediately, pending repairs to the room and a reassessment of need. This is not a romantic narrative of a successful escape: rent, advance, water, and possible conditions of return remain genuine obstacles. The cup Manjari wishes to take to her next home at the end of

the chapter makes personal continuity visible through an ordinary object. Leaving a shelter does not require relinquishing one's small possessions or memories.

Register of Direct Events: Meetings, Agreements, and Limited Outcomes

Initial condition: Ruhani holds the central key; Champa and Manjari stand on the threshold of independent decisions. First causal change: a collective meeting with Rukhsana and Zubaida decides on two extra copies of the main gate key, emergency contacts, and written allocation of responsibilities. Nobody is granted exclusive authority to unlock private rooms. Second difficulty: Hiravati Kurariyar's safe market space for weaving mats risks being labelled "encroachment" without a survey. Tara distinguishes the danger-marked track from the actual weaving place. A demand for inspection, a hearing, and payment for time is entered, but rights to the site are not immediately recognised. Third change: Hari Natuwa agrees to a performance of only the first two hours instead of the whole night, to protect his son Anshu's school hours. Javed Kalandar receives an amended programme agreement for shadow art instead of animal performance. Chandra Badi requires separate permission regarding her stage name, photographs, videos, songs, and arrears; a request to change the printed material is not merely a pencil correction. Fourth change: the office requests every shelter resident's private address and the identity of keyholders in one list. Ruhani and Rukhsana propose providing safety details separately, while Naira rejects inferring a current residential identity from a lane name in an old wage record. Outcome: public information on building safety is proposed; the additional request for private details remains under review, and no final relief decision has been made. By day's end, sharing the keys has been tested in practice, the first instalment for the programme has arrived, the date of outstanding pay is recorded, and Manjari's move has advanced.

This register permits an assessment of actual event density. The chapter has many new people and papers, but every occurrence of "a name being recorded" must not be counted as a separate narrative victory. Its central changes occur on three levels: recognition of personal decisions, limited economic agreements for performances, and partial decentralisation of institutional power. Hiravati's right to her place, Chandra's earlier arrears, and the shelter's assistance decision remain unresolved.

Labour, Identity, and the Illusory Image: Narrative Technique

Hari accepts reduced earnings rather than treating his son's time as free labour for his own artistic enterprise. Javed faces insecurity in changing his old occupation, but accepts the risk of "fewer tickets" for a performance

without captive animals. The shadow bird that appears on the screen and disappears offers something like a visual obliquity (vakrokti): no bird is bound; its presence is created by the artist. The audience's amazement and the presence of a real animal in a show are distinct things. Within the narrative, this scene is also a small exercise in epistemology: do not mistake appearance for actual presence. Chandra rejects the assumption that her caste automatically determines her occupation or makes her body available. The page of folk songs and incomplete payment preserve both the language of her art and its economic history.

Instead of long interior monologues, the narrator creates meaning through dialogue, small objects, and agreements. Focalisation shifts among Ruhani, Manjari, Champa, Hari, and Chandra, but no separate epic scene from the past interrupts the modern present. This clear limitation must be understood as a feature of the actual narrative arrangement, beyond the general label "dialogue-dominated." The day's temporal span runs from a rusty morning lock to an empty cup at night, with a small jump marked by "the next morning." The boundaries of a private room and the functional boundary of the public gate become spatial metaphors of the narrative.

Achievement and Counterargument

The chapter's strongest scene is the final empty cup. Without repeating the official language of rights, it lets the reader experience Manjari's ownership of her own cup. Leaving Hiravati's right to a weaving place uncompleted preserves institutional complexity. A critical objection remains: on a single day, numerous disputes over shelter, craft markets, cultural performances, and office records are classified with extraordinary efficiency. Some characters seem to abandon their distinctive idioms for the same language of rights. Still, Hari's reduced remuneration, Chandra's unpaid arrears, and Manjari's advance that has not been reduced stand against this convenient resolution. The final meaning is that opening a common gate does not confer ownership of a private room. The image of the key in the title thus finds its dedicated narrative form.

Chapter 54 — A Ritual Without a Chief

The Signboard Without a Name: How Is a "Chief" Produced?

The morning after the decentralisation of the keys, a new signboard appears outside the storeroom: relief distribution requires approval by a "chief coordinator," but the place for the name is blank. This narrative incongruity is deliberate. The board first declares that authority is necessary, then directs the characters to fill the empty seat. Rukhsana objects to subsuming rice from three separate sources—relief supplies,

exchange for wages, and donations for children's meals—under a single label. Ruhani does not immediately tear down the board; she props it against the wall as an object of inquiry. An unauthorised order should be examined by questioning its source, purpose, and effects, rather than by destroying the document. That is the story's procedure.

Dulari Rajwar is pressured to link relief rice to her signature relinquishing a cooperative loan, thereby merging two different relationships: assistance and liability. Gurmeet Kaur wants a board acknowledging donors, but the use of donated money and artisans' wages must be shown separately. Durga Danuwar wants the path used to bring bamboo from the forest, older leftover poles, permits for new cutting, and the load-bearing capacity of safety railings recorded as distinct matters. Madhuri Dangi rejects the classification of women's time spent sorting makhana and drying greens at home as unpaid "household assistance." In these four social settings, appointing one chief might simplify the list of subjects, but would leave the list of rights incomplete.

Causal Sequence and Defined Outcomes

First scene: the undefined "chief coordinator" may become a precondition for feeding people. Second scene: in a philosophical debate between Udayana and a Mimamsaka guest, opening arguments and responses address sacrifice, prescriptive sentences, apūrva, adṛṣṭa, validity of cognition, and the need for an omniscient governor. Third scene: confronted by the immediate hunger of children in the modern courtyard, Rukhsana and Gurmeet separate already authorised supplies; with receipts kept by two members, they serve the day's meal without accepting the debt-waiver condition. Fourth scene: limited temporary use of Durga's leftover bamboo is permitted; mapping fresh cuts and full load-safety certification remain outstanding. Fifth scene: Madhuri has women's and men's working hours recorded separately; an excessively salty sample is revised and an order is placed for a small trial batch, not a large purchase. Sixth scene: an answer remains due regarding a donor's condition that wages be reduced, so the disputed funds cannot be assumed spent. Seventh scene: the old "chief coordinator" signboard is replaced with a list of contacts for particular tasks; the office has not yet issued routine approval. Eighth scene: Dulari refuses to sign a blank debt-waiver document and enters her name for a hearing on relief. Similar old vehicle numbers on rumour sheets do not generate a fresh allegation against a driver or worker. Final position: today's food has been served; the loan dispute remains open; fresh bamboo cutting is not authorised; the trial batch is limited; the donor has not responded; and the original philosophical debate remains unresolved.

This sequence shows that the story depends on the experience of delay between crisis and philosophical debate. After a lengthy central passage of ancient reasoning, the mention of a hungry child in the modern scene creates a sharp contrast between the time of ideas and the time of the body. Correcting documents is necessary, but it is not sufficient reason to stop serving food. The reader should not simplify the scene into an argument either for or against administration.

The Debate Between Udayana and the Mimamsaka: Acknowledging an Unproved Analogy

Passage 8 of the original chapter explicitly says that the time of ancient Mithila is not the same as that of modern Videhapur. The Mimamsaka guest does not deny that human agents perform sacrifices. He questions whether the fruit of duty and the authority of words require an additional omniscient chief. Udayana restrains his disciple's haste: an argument such as "the unseen is invisible, therefore worthless" is incomplete, for the Nyaya position itself discusses the unseen. This episode is a literary attempt at an impartial reconstruction of philosophical positions. The scene requires an opposing doctrine to be presented in its strongest form, not made ridiculous so that it can be defeated.

The guest asks for independent evidence of an omniscient speaker, questions the mutual dependence of proving the speaker through the Veda and the Veda through its speaker, and asks why there must be a "first teacher" if tradition is beginningless. An immediate objection is raised to the disciple Somesh's bell analogy: a bell needs a hand to ring, therefore a ritual requires God. The observed cause of a bell's sound does not automatically establish an invariable connection with an unseen cause of the fruits of duty or the world's order. This is a genuine test for a fallacy in reasoning, not a merely ornamental analogy. Udayana hears separately the disagreement about intrinsic and extrinsic validity (svataḥ and parataḥ prāmāṇya). The disagreement has not proved God; his entry of "incomplete" is important to the scene. Since the assumption of cosmic creation and dissolution is itself contested, an inference to an omniscient teacher "at a new beginning" does not rest on premises accepted by all parties.

The novelist establishes an imaginative similarity between the questions of the second stabaka of the Nyāyakusumāñjali and the modern office of "chief": is an additional controller indispensable? Yet the philosophical principle of an omniscient God and the practical need for an elected kitchen contact person belong to categorically different questions. The author's text protects this distinction: the ancient issue concerns the grounds of the world, religious statements, and knowledge; the modern one concerns distribution, wages, and institutional power. An answer in

one period is not a municipal order in the other. Statements ascribed to a classical work cannot responsibly be quoted as if checked against that original without inspecting the source; this critical analysis reasons only from the scene in the novel.

A Social Order of Evidence: Blank Signatures, Faulty Samples, and Real Hunger

The words "voluntarily relinquished the amount due" appearing on Dulari's slip prove the existence of that wording, not her consent: she has not signed. The written sentence is thus read with sound discrimination among kinds of evidence. The thickness of bamboo alone cannot establish the load-safety of a railing; fastenings and testing also matter. An overly salty sample is fit for rejection or revision, but declaring women's skill useless on that basis would be an error of generalisation. Inferring that two documents with similar numbers establish the same vehicle, passengers, and offence builds several levels of unproved connection. Here the analysis of cause and effect becomes a practical safeguard of rights.

Yet evidence-gathering does not become a reason for postponement without end. The decision to feed the children today is immediate. The chapter coordinates obligation and accounting ethically: costs are to be entered in the public register after testimony-based verification. The "ration and debt" dispute is not concealed by private charity. Durga insists on recording the correct limits of the work while accepting local environmental responsibility. Madhuri acknowledges the fault in the taste but proposes that the consequence should not be to reduce the wages already agreed for the workers. Resistance is therefore practised not merely as refusal but as an alternative design for institutions.

Narrative Composition, Artistic Force, and Limitations

The narrative spans dawn to evening, interrupted by a separate ancient period of philosophical debate. The narrator preserves distinct idioms of tradition and modernity: the palm-leaf dialogue uses terms for validity, apūrva, creation, and dissolution; the kitchen speaks of grants, wages, rice, and bamboo thickness. The signboard is an institutional irony: the name is absent but the order is complete. Although the central philosophical passages are numerous, Rukhsana's remark while washing pots—"Today's food was saved, but the papers multiplied"—returns the discussion to embodied daily routine.

A critical limitation remains. Many communities and occupations enter the same small courtyard in rapid succession, each with a lucid statement suited to its rights. Such consistent classification is rare in social life, and at moments the story resembles a carefully planned book of examples. Yet the faulty salt, the donor's unanswered letter, Dulari's continuing fear, and the

municipality's withheld approval put cracks in this ideal procedure. The chapter's conclusion is not the literal declaration "No chief is needed." The roles of contact persons remain necessary, but must have a particular function and a defined right of refusal. What is at issue is not the need for coordination but the legitimacy of unlimited authority.

Chapter 55 — The Missing Child's Mother

Mithun's Absence: The Centre of Narration Is Not the “Search” but the Time of the Searcher

The chapter begins with three old tickets spread beside the hearth in Lata's home. The station stamp survives on one; perspiration has blurred the fare on another; the third is torn in half. The ordering of events is reversed here. Mithun's disappearance, the principal event, does not occur within this chapter's time: it has already happened, yet its unresolved outcome continues to alter the meaning of every object. The blank page does not record the time and expense consumed by searching. This detail prevents Lata's grief from becoming abstract pathos; it becomes time taken from and dishonoured in labour. The notebook has entries for “last seen” and “time of report,” but where are the intervening journeys, uncertain meals, lost wages and sleepless nights to be entered? That question makes a temporal interval in the plot into a social scene.

Naira does not pressure Lata to repeat her first statement. She asks permission for Lata to add, in her own words, what was omitted. Lata describes the time of the child's disappearance and the time when the household's food diminished as two distinct truths. This is the chapter's central achievement in its treatment of experienced time: the duration of grief is not identical with the timestamp on an official report. The narrator does not replace Lata's individual consciousness with an omniscient declaration. Instead, the conflict among her limited recollections, surviving tickets and accounts of her work generates layers of time.

Chronicle of Events: Evidence of Disappearance and Actions to Prevent False Accusations

Initial situation: eight-year-old Mithun remains missing. Lata's earlier statement records the time of the incident but does not fully account for the time and expense of searching. First intervention: Lata's younger brother expresses guilt; she instructs him to distinguish what he saw from what he did not see in a separate statement. Second action: a blue kurta, a red scarf whose dye runs, and a broken sandal strap become descriptive features of the search; five matching sandals have already been shown, and none is sufficient identification. Third change: Lata draws four chalk lines in the courtyard to construct a chronology of the search, keeping the stamped police-station time distinct from an estimated time at the market. Fourth problem: receipts substantiate two of the four days of Bhola Yadav's milk deliveries; receipt for the other two remains under

examination, and the uncertainty is not inserted into a chain of rumours about child theft. Fifth change: Poonam Chiridimar separates memories of her family's former occupation from her present earnings sewing sack covers; the accusation based on a community nickname is rejected. Sixth obstacle: someone attempts to add a new vehicle number and time to an old rumour leaflet, redirecting the search into a fresh allegation. The original receipt contains no return time, and the year attached to an older numeral is incomplete; the information is entered as "unverified" and its public circulation is stopped. Seventh event: Arun Barnwal separates publicity for charity from tax arrears. He pays an ascertainable amount due and leaves the older disputed assessment for examination. Eighth: Lata's four-day search register sets ticketed expenditures, times based on statements, and estimated lost wages in three separate rows; the oil-shopkeeper's limited testimony is added. Outcomes: Poonam's first consignment is accepted, Bhola receives payment for two days, and Lata is promised a contact list for the next day of searching. No newly verified information establishes where Mithun is.

The order of these incidents is not the conventional sequence in which the mystery of a disappearance is solved. It consists instead of excluding misleading possibilities so that a real search may continue. Lata's questions —whose eyes witnessed the information, what stamp establishes its time, who holds the original leaflet—mark her development as a character. At first every red thread or sandal quickens her breath; subsequently she refuses to run all night along the riverbank without reliable verification of time and place. Her grief has not lessened. What has changed is her capacity to decide from within grief.

Discipline of Evidence: Memory, Testimony, Inference, and Public Accusation

The oil-shopkeeper confirms that Lata's younger brother visited the shop, but cannot certainly remember where Mithun was at that moment. From the perspective of valid reasoning, partial testimony must not be extended to prove an entire proposition. A vehicle receipt gives a distribution date but leaves the return-time field empty. Matching numerals on two documents prove neither that the vehicle was the same nor, still less, that Mithun travelled in it. Red thread occurs in many scarves: the resemblance between Poonam's stitching and Mithun's clothing cannot establish an invariable connection with a particular crime. In these scenes the formal logic of the narrative is not merely the injunction "prevent accusations," but the indispensable contextual limits of each piece of evidence.

Poonam writes in one register what she learned from her grandmother about bird-catching methods, seasonal migration routes and the family's

departure from its former occupation. In another she enters today's dimensions and wages for sewing sack covers. From the standpoint of Videha's parallel-history perspective, this division matters. A marginalised or itinerant community can be the narrator of its own past; its community name is not independent evidence for an institution's suspicion of crime. A changed livelihood does not erase history, nor should a historical label steal the identity of present work. Bhola Yadav's daughter hears her father speak of offering water to someone who asks for food, but also learns to keep accurate accounts of credit. Sympathy and calculation are not opposed ethical substances.

Arun's episode supports this same approach to evidence at a different social level. A colourful banner advertising a charity fund does not certify the official discharge of tax arrears. He folds the banner and obtains an actual tax-payment receipt, without calling the money spent on publicity a relief expense. A proposal to redirect Madan's patient-transport vehicle in pursuit of a missing-child rumour is likewise not accepted. The truth of Lata's search does not annul a patient's right to treatment. The sequence prevents multiple social crises from becoming competing claims upon compassion.

Time, Focalisation, and the Beauty of Small Objects

The scenes move from the morning tickets to the daytime assistance desk, milk distribution, the market and night at home. Parallel actions at several places create a broad social setting without dislodging Lata's unbearable uncertainty as the emotional focus. When the narrator adds the cost of spoiled vegetables, Bhola's unpaid milk bills and Rukhsana's kitchen expenses, compassion is translated into institutional arithmetic. These are not perfunctory details. They answer the practical danger that the working woman's time spent searching will remain invisible.

The small clay horse belonging to Mithun produces the chapter's strongest aesthetic double register. One ear is broken; the boy had coloured its front blue and its back green. Lata remembers a joke he made about his sandal strap. The memory does not become an investigative exhibit: it remains a surviving experience of household intimacy. A plate also becomes an image of resistance to the pain of disappearance. Lata fills it with rice but does not leave it at the door; at last she serves rice for herself. There is no miraculous return, yet in the midst of self-neglect there is a small act on behalf of life. The effect of karuna-rasa arises not from sensational incident but from brief recurrences of action, pause and memory.

In relation to the earlier chapters about the search for Mithun, Chapter 55 makes a significant change. The external struggle against false accusations now becomes Lata's own way of ordering knowledge. Naira assists her but does not replace her voice. This limited shift in narrative voice opens the

possibility of a feminist narratological reading: the mother who has been made the subject of investigation determines how evidence is to be stated.

Critical Appraisal: Risks and Achievements

The chapter's achievement lies in marking "inference," "memory," and "direct confirmation" distinctly rather than dismissing a victim's uncertain account as inadequate. A child is missing, and the story does not manufacture an ending by blaming a few people. Small actions by supporting characters—Bhola's partial payment, Poonam's accepted consignment, Arun's tax receipt—preserve the economic life that continues around suffering. There is, however, a limitation: in some scenes Lata, Naira, Poonam, Bhola, Arun and Rukhsana speak in an almost equally orderly language of evidence, leaving little room for the disconnected, contradictory or apparently meaningless impulses of actual grief. The abundance of scattered clue-like objects can also draw the reader's attention away from the main search. The narrative partially compensates through the clay horse, the plate and the unexplained pause before eating. Its final position is decisive: Mithun has not been found; a practical search plan has been drawn up. These two truths must not be set against each other.

Chapter 56 — Medicine Given in Charity

Gratitude for Treatment and the Right to Scrutiny: The Opening Ethical Conflict

The chapter opens with a small bodily action by Jamuna Devi: she steps down from the cot, sets her feet on the ground and puts on her slippers unaided. After the earlier severity of her illness, this action is an experiential result of treatment, not an entry in a hospital ledger. Kanchan brings her prescriptions, tickets and two old photographs. Her mother does not object to remembering those who helped her with gratitude, but observes that bowing her head will not alter the hospital papers. The initial treatment, outside examinations, payments for medicine and the charity fund's contribution are not reduced to one person's miracle. The novel thus avoids the cheap opposition between gratitude and rights: treatment has helped her, and that benefit does not cancel the need to inspect the medicine stores and vehicle charges.

Outside the hospital, the shared kitchen's meeting on wages is underway. Jamuna expresses the joy of arriving on her own feet; accepting a stool, asking for air and eating a light meal remain modest choices she makes for herself. Through this precise bodily focalisation, the large public issues of scrutiny and accounts are not detached from the life of a particular

patient. Instead of an omniscient claim about the efficacy of medicine, the narrator places before us the limited experience of a body regaining its ability to act.

Accounting for Work: Raghu, Chandrika, and Gurmeet

An attempt is made to enter the roasted chickpeas supplied by Raghu Sahu's roasting-house under a single heading, "donation." Raghu distinguishes the costs of raw materials, roasting and labour. He does not tear up the slip; with a red pen he alters its classification. Here dissent speaks through economic analysis more than negative anger. Chandrika Rai prepares light jaggery cakes. Her customers have declined, so an order from the communal kitchen could provide genuine income. She distinguishes cakes for children from rice and porridge for patients and does not convert a grant into a merchant's windfall. Gurmeet maintains three accounts—purchased goods, donated goods, and wages or fair profit. Chandrika has actually made seventy cakes; another group's output cannot be included in her count. The narrative creates a minute site of economic transparency: gratitude on the purchaser's part is no licence to erase real costs.

When Raghu is asked for a second consignment on credit, uncertainty about payment returns. Jamuna intervenes: his roasting-house must not close in the name of her survival. Chandrika identifies the general rule at issue. A fund may pay for medicine and a kitchen may supply food, but if workers' payments are postponed at both places, the true cost of assistance vanishes from sight. This economic discussion can be read as a form of rural and semi-urban Maithili labour's own language. At moments, however, the narrator's formulaic propositions also weigh more heavily than the characters' immediate speech.

Medical Aid, Inspection, and the Separation of Evidence

Hospital staff say that an inspection team will examine medicine stock and actual vehicle-travel expenses the following week. Some people want the charity fund's contribution formally honoured first. Jamuna asks why her day of thanksgiving must be tied to the inspection procedure. She confirms that she received financial assistance, but will not have the private details of her illness read aloud to a crowd. She consents to sharing a limited copy showing dates, heads of expenditure and amounts. The distinct domains of medical confidentiality and transparency in public accounts constitute the chapter's principal evidentiary question.

Devvrat himself is absent from the public meeting. His office assistant fears that damage to the fund's reputation might interrupt medicine for poor patients. This oral statement is not treated as Devvrat's written order. In

the evening a two-page letter authorising financial support arrives; it gives the approved limit and amount actually received, but does not automatically pronounce the hospital, warehouse and vehicle accounts entirely beyond reproach. Jamuna directly asks the assistant whether he is citing a written office instruction or expressing his own fear. The novel's achievement in the theory of evidence lies in recognising the limits of both answers. “The patient survived” does not entail “every bill is correct”; nor does “an investigation is needed” entail “all assistance was fraudulent.”

Aditi, on the inspection team, separates the matters to be examined: the approved vehicle fare, actual journeys, quantities of medicine received and withdrawals from hospital stores. The author resists the temptation to establish guilt in advance. A similarity in a transport document or source number, even if it also appears in the search for Mithun and the gate's wage register, cannot automatically produce a single criminal network. Naira creates three independent headings—Mithun's search, medicine-transport accounts, and the public route at the gate and water lease—and labels conjectural linkages “unverified.” Rather than forging one causal chain out of three political-social crises, the novel respects the limits of unrelated evidence.

Chronicle of Direct Events: Individual Decisions and Surviving Uncertainties

Opening: after treatment, Jamuna regains limited independent mobility and attends the public meeting. First dispute: Raghu, Chandrika and Gurmeet establish separate accounts for donations, raw materials, labour and reasonable profit. Second dispute: while acknowledging the charity fund's contribution, Jamuna reserves the right to inspect warehouse and vehicle records and restricts publication of her private medical information. Third episode: Suraj Chaudhary calculates separately the time involved in climbing and cutting palm trees, collecting leaves and sap, sanitation and packaging; his father gives his first written conditional consent, not a declaration that the beverage business has succeeded. Fourth: a red mark for road widening threatens Bela Turha's fish stall. Her established business is documented, but land ownership is not. She requests measurement and comparison of two possible locations, one near the school and the other by the peepal tree; no final relocation site is secured. Fifth: Kamala Jain separates grain donations and shop receipts from decisions concerning her personal observance; an internal family dispute is not settled over the public microphone. Sixth: an official letter sets out the authorised amount of medical assistance; the inspection of expenditure remains. Seventh: today's approved meal is served; no public authorisation has been given for the following three days. Outcomes: Suraj's father's qualified consent, scrutiny of Bela's alternative sites, Kamala's bounded

family decision, and Jamuna's written gratitude coupled with her insistence on investigation.

Nothing in this list permits the claim that a medicine scam has been proved or Bela has obtained a new stall. Jamuna's improvement is not imaginary, and the next three days of kitchen operations are not yet guaranteed. In the last scene Tara studies a plan for Bela's alternative market site; an agricultural worker asks where the drainage line runs. Because this environmental issue remains open, the Udyoga Parva's social contract is not transformed into an irreversible conclusion.

Body, Trade, Religious Practice, and Waterside Space: The Limited Achievement of Polyphony

The cost of the physical danger incurred by Suraj's father when climbing trees is entered separately. This is not the conventional conflict between modernity and the past over an inherited occupation. Suraj does not abandon the palm tree; he demands appropriate payment for each stage of its work. His mother recalls the lack of initial capital, and the family's practical disagreement remains unsettled. Bela produces evidence of her regular fish trade, but it does not establish ownership of the site. Official survey lines, monsoon drainage and customers' ability to reach her determine the conditions of her livelihood. Kamala distinguishes commercial accounts for grain from her independent decision on religious vows; she neither ridicules religious tradition nor submits trade accounting to religious regulation. What these roles share is not merely resistance but an ability to decide within their distinct circumstances.

Narrative focalisation shifts from Jamuna's body to Gurmeet's account books, Suraj's family tension, Bela's red mark and Kamala's disagreement at home. The narration spans one day from morning through evening, night and the journey home; recollections of treatment create analepsis within it. Jamuna's grandson brings a half-cooked cake. She encourages his enthusiasm for cooking while refusing to eat food that is not cooked properly. The human force of this small moment of humour is greater than a declaration of restored health: affection and the caution necessary after illness coexist. At home Jamuna's reminder to take her afternoon medicine on time indicates that bodily autonomy is not an unqualified release from dependence, but the practical discipline of self-care.

The Resonance of Charity, Artistic Achievement, and Critical Limitation

The title “Medicine Given in Charity” holds both the gentleness of gratitude and the danger of domination. Morning dew on the medicine vial, followed by Jamuna laughing at her grandson's cake, gives that

tension a human location. From the standpoint of Indian poetics, there is a brief movement among compassion, tranquillity and humour; the central suggestion, or dhvani, is that a person's survival does not become anyone else's property for self-glorifying publicity. Raghu's red pen, Bela's red road mark and the fund's two-page letter inhabit different semantic economies despite shared colours or paper. The critic need not melt them into a single symbol.

The limitation is the characters' repeated insistence on "separate accounting heads." When such divisions recur every few sentences, the reader may at times feel that the narrative has become a critical essay. The inner lives of the dissenting assistant, elder or official are relatively underdeveloped. Polyphony therefore exists at the thematic level but does not everywhere become complete ideological independence. Yet Jamuna's recovering body, Kanchan's fear, Suraj's mother's anxiety about capital, Bela's doubt about finding customers at a new market and the uncertainty over the next three days of meals give the carefully reasoned proposals a genuine setting. The concluding passage discloses another relation between truth and thanks: one can write gratitude for help without surrendering the right to investigate it.

Udyoga Parva / Kishkindha Kanda: Combined Assessment of Chapters 53–56

From a Single Centre of Authority to Distinct Domains of Work

In Chapter 53 the keys are distributed: safety at the public gate is a shared responsibility, while the boundaries of private rooms remain protected. In Chapter 54 the notice naming a "chief coordinator" is replaced by a task-based contact list. In Chapter 55 the mother herself revises the search register according to distinctions within her experience; limited personal evidence takes precedence over collective enthusiasm for rumours. In Chapter 56 approved medical assistance, inspection of stores and medical confidentiality become separate domains of authority. Across these chapters the debate over a "chief" unfolds at four levels: locks, signatures for distribution, the speaker of testimony and the moral authority of a donor. Their causal relationships are not identical everywhere. The distribution of keys illuminates the question of the noticeboard in the next chapter; Lata's search document prepares the ground for resisting misleading similarities of numbers in later medicine records. Criticism must keep these levels distinct.

The Place of Ramayana–Mahabharata and Philosophical Intertexts

The fifth parva as a whole raises the Kishkindha Kanda's problem of unequal alliances. Chapters 53 and 55 contain no clearly separate Ramayana-time scenes: the modern characters' autonomy in shelter and search predominates. Chapter 54 has an independent ancient debate between Udayana and a Mimamsaka, engaging the arguments of the Nyayakusumanjali. It would contradict the text to treat that debate as Sugriva's royal court or as an episode of a Mahabharata parva. In Chapter 56 the main narrative concerns bodily treatment, labour and inspection. A broad indication of two temporal strands is insufficient by itself to prove the presence of a particular epic counterpart. Distinguishing a parva's structural name from demonstrable, separately narrated scenes is essential to scholarly integrity in these four chapters.

The principal narratological exercise in this sequence is to test whether the means of proof legitimately establishes the proposed conclusion: a shared key does not confer private ownership; a relief-loan slip does not prove Dulari's consent; red thread does not identify a child abductor; approved medicine does not establish the integrity of all transport accounts. Yet human decisions remain necessary in each instance. "Checking evidence" does not become a heartless postponement. Children must be fed on time, Jamuna must receive care, and Lata needs a limited, practical plan for searching. These are demands of immediate action.

Local Histories of Labour and Distinct Forms of Livelihood

Hiravati Kurariyar's mats, Hari Natuwa's drum, Javed Kalandar's shadow theatre, Chandra Badi's songs, Durga Danuwar's bamboo knowledge, Madhuri Dangi's makhana processing, Poonam Chiridimar's modern sewing, Bhola Yadav's milk, Raghu Sahu's roasting-house, Chandrika's sweets, Suraj's palm trees and Bela Turha's stall cannot adequately be subsumed under one category, "marginal communities." Each occupation carries distinct material risks, payment arrangements, gender relations and forms of institutional evidence. A parallel-history perspective treats their local knowledge and labour as independent historical materials, not charity outside official institutions' tables. Nevertheless, certain conditions of formal decisions about rights cannot be met through oral memory alone: Tara's site measurements, Aditi's inspections, signatures and verification of actual receipt are equally necessary.

Achievements, Repetition, and Questions for Further Inquiry

The overarching artistic achievement lies in staging relations of power through modest objects: Ruhani's lock, Lata's torn ticket, Dulari's blank signature and Jamuna's prescription slip. Such objects acquire meaning

within narrated scenes rather than serving only as examples from a manifesto. Moments of compassion—Champa's chosen day off, Manjari's cup, Lata's clay horse and the cake made by Jamuna's grandson—give the severity of account-book analysis a human pause. The plot's limitation is that too many characters introduce a new form or a perfectly differentiated category. Their distinctive vocabularies risk being replaced by a collectively ordered language of argument. Subsequent chapters must examine whether the temporary decentralisation of keys survives in practice, whether institutional redress is obtained for pressure on Dulari to waive a debt, whether independent direct evidence emerges in Mithun's search, and whether the charity fund's documents yield actual corrections to vehicle accounts. The present four chapters do not permit these outcomes to be invented.

Chapter 57 — Janaka and the People of the Realm

The Bamboo Sinking into a Field Boundary: Direct Knowledge and the Distance of the Survey Register

The chapter begins when a bamboo pole sinks into the bund around a field. This is more than a visual opening: it stages a tangible collision between the level line drawn on paper and the resistance of the soft clay beneath the surface. Ramesh does not sing the praises of abstract “folk knowledge” against Tara's survey without consent; he asks the official to step onto the land and understand the danger underfoot. Tara records the two hours he has taken away from work, but makes clear that receipt of wages does not finally settle land rights. The novel's evidentiary discipline is unusually precise here: the fact of an event and the right it might be asked to prove are different matters. A survey book is necessary, but cannot replace the entirety of experience on the ground.

An earthen heap belonging to a landowner has blocked Dhani Rajbhar's old irrigation channel, affecting both rented farmland and another household's courtyard. Dhani's speech articulates the tension between ownership and the right of use. The novel offers no simple maxim against the state or private property. In a subsequent scene Dhani himself acknowledges the landowner's fear that the boundary might collapse and supports a temporary, supervised opening. The initial opposition therefore does not remain a mere contest of “owner versus labourer”; it becomes a question of responsibility for different kinds of harm within a shared system of water.

In Sushila Mahato's seed trial, two field plots each have eight rows; different degrees of waterlogging and the recorded formation of ears in five to seven rows provide its results. Sushila challenges the advertisement's

claim to work in "all conditions," but does not proclaim a comparison between two plots a scientific conclusion applicable everywhere. Mahendra, representing the company, raises differences in preparation, while Pawan, a new trainee, asks about the drying period. These three statements occupy different positions. Mahendra circles the words "all conditions" but gives no promise of correction; Pawan preserves his notebook. The story reaches a finding that the advertisement's unqualified wording is unsupported, not a finding of corporate guilt or an agreement on compensation.

Janaka's Ancient Court: Philosophical Debate and an Unanswered Question from the Fields

In passages 8–10 a separate ancient temporal strand opens in Mithila. A worker from the fields shows the clay adhering to a ploughshare in a gathering devoted to knowledge. Janaka breaks the ceremonial order to hear him. The question "Will the course of water change because a king says so?" discloses the limits of royal pronouncement. A learned woman asks about the criterion for knowing; a scholar opens a discussion of the Self's non-attachment, yet no one in the court asks about the worker's right to his own field. It would be a mistake to treat this scene as a historical account of governance under Janaka. It is the novelist's imagined shastrartha, an unfinished conversation between the celebrated wisdom of the philosopher-king and the experience of an unknown worker.

The effect of the two temporal strands is not confined to resemblance between names. The ancient ploughshare and modern bamboo pole both disclose information below the earth's surface. The old royal register and contemporary survey register can both record dissent and conceal rights. Yet in Janaka's court the king himself orders an inspection; in the modern assembly several stakeholders divide among themselves the limits of decision-making. This contrast imaginatively evokes a long political transformation in the collective making of evidence; it is not a definitive historical verdict of progress. The Janaka-time scene returns in passage 27, when two families demand opposing decisions about a channel. With that return, the opening word "knowledge" becomes an open question rather than instruction furnished with a final answer.

Lease, Net, Nursery, and Sarangi: Consent Is Not One Uniform Thing

Meena Tharu's family faces both the immediate pressure of advance medical expenses and uncertain terms for a long agricultural lease. Meena submits a written objection to the possibility that her father's illness could be used to construct tacit consent. She does not tear up the document, nor does she advocate interrupting her father's treatment. The narrative offers no instant answer to her mother's question: who will put in writing that

improving the channel will not flood the house? The father-daughter discussion remains open on a promise to read the next page together. The original text neither declares that Meena has "saved the land" nor that the lease has been legally annulled.

Fifteen old knot marks on Phoolmati Tiyar's fishing net preserve the memory of work. On that basis she demands that the sale price and previous repairs be accounted for separately. Registration of a new net-making group begins under four names, but an old partnership dispute has not ended. "Puraini," the name recorded in Nandini's nursery water account, is an older local name for a water source, not a verified map showing its confluence with a present river. In response to Sushila's objection about costs, Nandini undertakes to show the water measurements the next day but does not agree to lower the price. A distinction arises between Dev Gaine's inherited tune, his own performance and a new stanza; a restricted offer to perform is not a final contract. Although the material forms in these episodes differ, each checks the conversion of a limited right of use into unlimited ownership.

Chronicle of Events, Narrative Time, and Focalisation

Initial situation: the actual movement of water through the land conflicts with the survey papers, while workers' time, crops and advertising claims are disputed. First deviation: the ancient court of Janaka shows an official order of knowledge interrupted by a question from the fields. Second cluster of conflicts: Meena's lease, Phoolmati's net, Nandini's prices and Dev's performance raise distinct objections. Collective meeting: Tara prevents maps, seed tests, leases and public drainage from being merged into a single determination; the right to a permanent public route is reserved for a later hearing. Final situation: Dhani receives limited permission to clear grass in the presence of two families, together with a written record of wages due; Meena's family negotiations remain open; and a list of water-related losses is entered on a new page.

Narrative time runs from a morning on the field bund to rain at night, interrupted by scenes set in ancient Mithila: a separate story-time, not an ordinary flashback in a modern character's memory. The third-person narrator presents many stakeholders. Tara is a major point of connection, but the reader also encounters the concerns of Meena's father, the curiosity of Sushila's son Vinay, Phoolmati teaching others, and the discussion between Dev and Ragini. Vinay's clod of earth, dry on the surface yet moist within, becomes a visual suggestion: surface dryness says nothing conclusive about underground water. This experience turns the chapter's resistance to hasty inference from an essayistic proposition into narrative action.

Narrative Tests and an Artistic Counterargument

"The bamboo sank" is a directly observed event. "A particular underground watercourse caused it" is not yet an established conclusion. Sushila's trial includes only two plots: these examples cannot establish a guaranteed harvest in all conditions. Inferring a distant river confluence from the nursery record's name "Puraini" would be a fallacy arising from verbal resemblance. Phoolmati's knot marks testify to labour but do not provide conclusive legal proof of every clause of an earlier sales agreement. These distinctions make useful narratological demands upon evidence; the novel does not deliver the verdict of an actual court.

An artistic achievement is the production of disputes over knowledge from the life of things: a ploughshare bearing clay, a water vessel, knots, a wet ledger, a sarangi and a clod surrounding a seed. The critical limitation is equally apparent. Farmers, officials, artisans, performers and children explain with remarkable clarity that one right does not entail another. In several strands, "write it on a separate line" becomes a uniform language of resolution. The untidy resistance of emotion is given less space. Yet Meena's father remains silent, Mahendra does not promise correction and Nandini refuses to lower her price. These undecided matters prevent the chapter from becoming pure instruction.

Chapter 58 — The Web of Causes

Many Currents Within Apparently Still Water

The apparently motionless water of the Makhaniya pond turns a leaf backwards beneath its surface. The opening gives the title, "The Web of Causes," a physical form. Ramani Bind's bamboo probe brings up silt, rotting leaves and the threads of a sack, but these things do not instantly identify one guilty person. Ramani's primary demand is separate documentation of the time for planting makhana seeds, the water conditions of fields in the floodplain and the safety instructions for opening the channel. At Hira's suggestion Tara marks times for measuring in the morning, at noon and after rain. The channel is straight on the map but curves on the ground; cutting it straight could send water into Phoolo's betel-leaf plots. Thus the narrative continuously distinguishes forecasts of physical change, stakeholders' testimony and decisions about actual work.

Phoolo Chaurasia fears that the earth of a new embankment will cover the roots of her betel plants. When an official invokes the formula "everyone must sacrifice," she asks, "Who is to make the sacrifice?" Ramesh raises the need for advance notice before changing his vegetable crop and the question of possible compensation. Devaki Pal sees fast market vehicles

and delayed income as threats to a higher route used for moving animals; Neeraj's question gives the cost of delay a household meaning. Batohi Dhami distinguishes gathering honey and protecting trees from unlawful hunting. Sabina Mirshikar rejects the inference of smuggling or prohibited hunting merely from a community name. To classify all these communities as an abstract camp of "environmental supporters" would erase their differing positions.

Seeds, Debt, and Wages: A False Reckoning of Profit

Sowing makhana seeds, gathering leaves and cracking dried makhana are separate labour processes. The assumption that the person whose name appears on the pond lease has received every worker's full profit is broken by the sight of blisters on the women's palms. Paras Lal argues that deductions are warranted by an advance for seeds; Ramani asks to see three distinct accounts—seed expenditure, pond lease and advances to women workers. Paras does not disclose the underlying figures, postponing the matter until the owner's arrival. The chapter has therefore not reached a verdict that "the debt has been proved false." Its immediate achievement is the identification of separate obligations and unpaid labour. The women copy down the dates of payments they actually received; this personal making of evidence marks a new phase of the collective dispute.

Nandini refuses to treat her four days of nursery measurements as a determination of water movement across the entire floodplain. Jayaram proposes using that limited information to lower the rate of land compensation; Nandini replies that sharing measurements does not signify consent to sell land. "Balthi" is Saroj Kharkaut's local term for a group that sews fishing nets, not a drainage outlet. "Badadari," in Sushila's account, is the place-name of a field plot, not the name of a verified river. Here the novel turns the plurality of a word's meanings into a practical crisis of evidence. To assume that the referent is identical simply because the word is identical offers a useful literary focus on the subtle problem of the determining qualification, or avacchedaka.

Seasonal Time: Different Uses of the Same Place

In the monsoon the western floodplain is used for fish and grazing animals; when the water withdraws it becomes land for rice and vegetables. To disregard the seasonal transition and determine permanent water rights from "today's water" would be a temporal error. Ramani's old boat mark tells us about the previous monsoon, not by itself about the present water-tax lease. The application to add women leaseholders' names has not yet been accepted. Tara adds a corrective note beside the old page's "permanent water line"; she does not erase the original line and clean the

past of its error. The correction matters because both the old mistake and new knowledge remain legible.

Phoolo, Ramesh and Devaki propose different periods for decisions: one night can damage betel plants, five days matter to transplanting vegetables, and two hours of safe passage matter on the wool-market route. A new hive on Batohi's honey route creates an immediate ecological danger. After visiting with assistant Manju, a conditional route along the dry northern bund is proposed. The environment is not simply symbolic here; it is a living system moving at different speeds. Without this mismatch between narrated time and ecological time, the policy question of opening the channel cannot be fully understood.

Chronicle of Events: Expanded Inspection and Deferred Decisions

Initial situation: no adequate joint measurement exists for water flow and makhana planting, while the old map differs from the site. First group of disputes: different harms to betel, vegetables, livestock, honey collection and nets, together with social prejudice. Second set of evidence: labour and debt in makhana production, nursery measurements, recollections marked by old boats and the misconstrual of two local names. Third procedure: seasonal proposals, conditional routes for animals and honey gatherers, old receipts suggesting that payments can be traced, and public measurement instead of an ornamental celebration. Fourth and decisive outcome: large-scale cutting is halted; conditions are written for safe measurement, separate hearings, warnings and a labour register. Only temporary clearing of rubbish near the small measuring opening is permitted. At the end, the committee across the river sends a letter requesting joint inspection but asking for restricted circulation of household names.

This account shows that the chapter does not end with “the channel was opened.” Even after five conditions, the line for “permission to open today” remains blank. Initial leads emerge concerning three sequences of benefit—obstructed water, ghat fees and production loans—but Naira refuses to infer a single criminal or intention. An unsupported rumour joining an old hospital vehicle to Mithun's disappearance is returned because it lacks corroborated time, vehicle number or eyewitness testimony. The failure of the allegation is an important negative event in the narrative's craft: the reader is spared the false ease of an unearned mystery solution.

Narrative Arrangement, Evidence, and Tests of Limitation

Within the present-day frame, extending from dawn to night, anticipated rain, a coming dry season, the nursery's preceding four days and memories of an old boat mark supply four concurrent scales of time. There is no

separate scene of ancient philosophical debate in this chapter; the opening reference to a "two-time intertext" must not be mistaken for a fact of scene construction. In classical terminology, examining a web of causes—the subject, reason, invariable relation and limiting condition—takes place in the modern measurements and rumours. "Paras's account is incomplete" does not establish the invariable implication "Paras is a criminal"; an old river-name does not entail the present outlet. Responsible inference must look for limiting conditions and practical counterevidence.

The artistic strength lies in showing the time of particular bodies within a multi-sided water conflict: the wool carried by Devaki and Neeraj, blisters from the women's makhana work, Sabina's needle, Batohi's honey vessel and a paper boat that Kanchan sets spinning. The child's question—pushing a toy boat will not open the actual blocked outlet—organises the causal resonance of the story. Its limitation is the artificial compression of a great multitude of occupations into one day's meeting; Tara and Naira classify every dispute with improbable speed and order. Yet Paras's loan, the original order for ghat charges, the leaseholder's name and warnings for the opposite bank remain unresolved. The procedure therefore never becomes a universal solution.

Chapter 59 — The Envoy's Conditions

"Restricted Circulation": Two Pages of a Letter and the Right to Speak

The sealed letter arriving at the end of Chapter 58 becomes the causal opening of Chapter 59. Tara handles its damp envelope with care; the committee on the opposite bank has written "restricted circulation." Naira separates its request for a public joint inspection from the private list of households and families. The action gives rise to a subtle narrative question: must people who demand public measurements of water also be obliged to publish the private details of their fear? In Jayaram's view, transparency means unrestricted circulation of a complete copy. Naira distinguishes transparency from the limits of representation and the safe use of information. The public part of the letter may be shared; permission to publish the confidential portion has not been obtained.

Because the boat's load measurements are incomplete, Hira will not make a definite claim about its passenger capacity. A water-level report is not evidence of safe passage for travellers. Shyam Mallik recalls that the family across the river was urgently concerned about a route by which children could escape. Thus the purpose of an official "joint inspection" is not merely to obtain information about water but to provide warnings before

a crisis. Separate calculations of the boatman's wages, load safety and the delay in returning show that the ethics of delivering news are incomplete without bodily safety and respect for an envoy's labour.

Hanuman's Two-Time Embassy: Token, Message, and Reply

From passage 5 the narrative opens a separate ancient-mythological strand at the seashore, with the search party, Angada, Jambavan, Hanuman and Rama's signet ring; that time returns in passage 17. The ring helps identify the envoy. It does not itself constitute Sita's reply or consent. The crucial reinterpretation is that the power to cross an ocean and the duty to understand the news and bring back an answer are distinct. Jambavan reminds Hanuman of his strength without reducing his mission to the temptation of glory. This scene should be read as the novel's imaginative retelling of epic material, not the uniquely authenticated version of every Ramayana text. The author constructs a moral analogy between the ancient messenger and the limits of the modern committee's authority, not a legal equivalence.

Having the ring does not establish that everything the messenger says must be accepted. Likewise, a modern letter is signed, but that does not grant ownership of its private page for publication. The ancient messenger waits for Sita's own answer, while the modern travellers await Shabnam's consultations with her members. In both cases the envoy is displaced from the seat of an independent and final judge. The Kishkindha Kanda's impulse towards courage is transformed here into a generous but bounded practice of conveying messages and listening to the reply.

Ownership of Samples and Translation of Folk Songs: Multiple Layers of Representation

In proposals to measure Rekha Sahu Laheri's lacquer work and test it by machine, a photograph of a single sample could become the basis of unlimited copies. Conditions are entered for three months of restricted testing, an advance sample fee, and retention of the original ledger by Rekha. This is not an unrestricted final manufacturing licence. Purchasing a wooden panel from Suman Tikulhar does not confer the right to print her motif on thousands of posters. Saroj Kharkaut records the net's thread, hours spent sewing it and the dangers of lowering it into water separately. Five members agree to the test, while two still object. It is unacceptable to make women workers' names invisible merely to simplify the sale of a single net.

Malati Koche connects her settlement's interest in the opposite-bank letter with the diminishing flow from a shared tap. Phoolmati Pamariya replaces a humiliating line of a song with a new line chosen in her own voice. She

separately demands an honorarium, accompanists' payment and credit for translation from the organiser. Padma explains the different meanings of "boundary": a field bund, an administrative limit and the separation of lovers. In Durga Danuwar's song, "Lakhandei" is a folk name or poetic expression, not an independently verified confluence on today's river survey. The critical point is to honour folk memory while recognising the limits of its geographical verification. Preserving tradition does not mean compelling a woman to repeat demeaning words without an alternative.

Chronicle of the Envoy's Direct Actions and Unfulfilled Rights

Initial situation: the members across the river want inspection, but insist on confidentiality for private addresses; the boat route and safety of its load have not been established. Middle expansion: the ancient envoy scene, agreements over the use of craftwork, division of capital and wages in net-making, Malati's water supply and the dispute over Phoolmati's translation. Pre-departure obstacles: agreement by telephone on a complete map or translated summary remains pending; two people bearing the same surname must not be identified as one without the original register; rumours about Mithun's disappearance remain subject to separate investigation. Meeting: the meaning of "ber" in the tap's record is re-examined, together with the possibility of advance warning, circulation of public measurements and private records, and division of responsibility. Outcome: agreement in principle to send a small inspection team, with a promise to seek members' permission before using the private list; however, the meaning of open access and Ramesh's compensation remain unresolved.

Hira does not make an unconditional technical promise that one day's advance notice will be possible in every sudden monsoon emergency. The dialogue avoids an immediately consoling consensus. The envoy's practical achievement is twofold: an authenticated copy preserves the public request, while the private list remains on a closed page. Jayaram deletes a blurred photograph, but the narrative does not claim that every risk of further digital circulation has vanished. The original documents in Mithun's search remain incomplete; the water lease awaits a separate hearing; and a comprehensive market licence for the craftwork is suspended. No water agreement yet exists.

Focalisation, Linguistic Meaning, and Narrative Limits

Focalisation shifts among Tara and Naira, Shabnam, Malati, the craftspeople, Padma and Phoolmati. The third-person narrator relates external actions and selected private experiences. During Phoolmati's song Padma keeps her translation notebook shut. Not everything has to be explained instantly: for a moment the narrative allows language its own

independent music. After that pause Malati records the hours during which water flows at the household tap. The memory of the song consequently does not become a literary ornament severed from daily work.

In the logic of the narrative, a shared surname does not prove that two persons are one; a third party's rumour is not direct evidence of a crime; and a dialect word cannot be assigned one fixed meaning without its sentence and context. Understanding verbal testimony raises questions about speaker, situation, intention and limits of use. The artistic achievement is to turn the physical distance of the envoy's journey into linguistic and ethical distance. Its limitation is the extraordinary range of matters assembled within one journey—sample designs, songs, wages, water measurements, the missing-child search and boat receipts. Many characters give similarly lucid explanations of "permission." Nevertheless, Phoolmati's song and a little sweet brought for Malati's daughter keep the chapter from narrowing to instruction in contracts alone.

Chapter 60 — The First Agreement Falls Through

The Unstable Line in the Rain: One Word, Several Kinds of Access

A charcoal line on a wet bamboo panel has spread. Yesterday it marked the width of the ghat; today its edges are unclear. The scene collectively questions the survey of the place, the representative's authority and written consent. Jayaram wants unrestricted entry onto private field boundaries so that "inspection" can be completed quickly. Shabnam Khatun asks who will recognise measurements taken without prior permission. Okra growing in Ramesh's field and an empty compensation column rescue "access" from the abstraction of public welfare. With two lengths of cord Hira distinguishes the old public footpath from the proposed inspection route across Ramesh's private field. Seeing a site from a distance and driving survey pegs into a field are not the same action.

Jagadish Jha urgently needs a medicine route for his sick daughter-in-law. Ramesh does not oppose it; he objects to imposing an uncompensated permanent vehicle road on private land under the name of emergency access for a patient. The expression "open access" therefore changes its intended meaning in three situations: use of an old public path, entry onto private land for inspection, and emergency travel to save life. The similarity of the words does not establish identical obligations. The legal assistant's proposal for "unrestricted access" fails to specify emergency, consent and payment for loss. Under pressure to sign first, the parties leave the proposal unsigned.

Labour on the Stage: Two Separate Accounts for Festival and Agreement

In the midst of the monsoon meeting, the register for the annual Phagun festival of public reading, open accounts and song is produced. In Rashid Bhat's song the four lines inherited from his grandmother and the three new lines of his own composition are distinguished. Consent to recite one line on stage is not permission to circulate an entire recording. Ramesh Ghasi brings the payment for his musical performance out of the zero-cost category of "public service," demanding fees for rehearsal, travel and performance. Karun Damai distinguishes time for repairing instruments from time spent playing them. Farzana Chudihar explains the separate costs and risks of handmade lacquer, glass and machine-produced bangles. Opening an account for the event does not approve the water agreement. But if collective decisions are to be read aloud on a public stage, the value of the hands that make the stage must also survive in history.

This cultural subplot might have strayed from the principal causal line. Naira makes its connection explicit: the "agreement" and its "public reading" are different acts. A Videha parallel-history perspective becomes relevant here on the basis of specific local evidence. Absorbing an old song under the anonymous category of "folk," treating a worker's accompaniment on stage as free, and erasing a woman's time repairing materials expose the selections by which official history is constructed. The novel does not thereby claim to formulate the actual law of water agreements.

Hanuman's Ring and the Limits of Representation

In passage 13 the separate ancient story-time of Kishkindha returns: Hanuman's strength, Rama's ring and the duty to listen to Sita's reply. This is a return to the messenger story of Chapter 59, not a new episode of crossing the sea. The ring identifies the envoy but does not extinguish Sita's choice. Shabnam's modern committee is not authorised to disclose all its members' confidential names. The personal identity of a claimant can be examined at an authorised hearing, not on a public platform. The epic intertext is justified in this regard: representation does not mean recording every part of another person's life as one's own property. Nevertheless, Sita and Hanuman's mythological relationship cannot be treated as judicially and legally identical with negotiations between two modern committees.

Old paint marks and an indistinct date on Hira's measuring staff do not establish its maximum load or flow capacity. Conversely, "incomplete measurement" does not mean "no safety work may ever be undertaken"; clearing rubbish from a safe bank remains possible. The conditions of a

modern envoy form a technical, linguistic and moral triangle: the limits of measurement, advance warning understood in the local language, and the actual extent of consent.

Decisive Chronicle of Events: Failed Negotiation and Five Possible Conditions

Initial situation: two committees seek public inspection but differ over consent for private fields, crop damage and the meaning of a route for patients. First obstacle: nobody signs the ambiguous proposal for "unrestricted access." Middle stage: payment for work at public events and the ancient dialogue of messengers supply the ethical background of disagreement. Decisive negotiation: the municipality seeks to merge rights over an old public footpath and a new inspection path; a majority across the river insists on prior consent before entry onto private bunds; Ramesh demands written assessment of harm, while Jagadish seeks a patient route. The secretary counts five members against the broad wording on entry, and three prepared to consider a conditional arrangement. This is not unanimity.

Naira writes a new heading: "First Agreement Unsuccessful: Five Possible Conditions for Consent to Testing." First, the public footpath, private bund and patient's emergency route must be distinguished, as must notification and permission to enter. Second, measurements in rain and drought, a safe measuring scale, technical testing and the way to remedy defects must be specified. Third, scheduled release of water requires advance notice, while sudden emergencies require separate immediate warnings accessible in local languages. Fourth, losses to crops, women's weeding wages, animal routes, nurseries, fish and makhana must receive distinct assessments and hearings. Fifth, public expenses for inspection, transport, craftwork, translation and safety tasks must be accounted for; circulation of private names must be restricted, and originals safeguarded. Acknowledgment copies for consideration of these five matters are received. Nobody signs the agreement itself.

Jayaram attempts to have the news report say that "open passage has been approved"; Shabnam herself strikes it out. An outside crowd accuses Ramesh of blocking a patient's route and Shabnam of hiding information. Jagadish and Naira correct these characterisations. The correction protects the reputations of both parties; it does not signify success of the water agreement. Later, at the annual Phagun gathering, the five conditions are read aloud. During the intervening months limited repairs have been carried out on the public footpath, but unrestricted access across private fields remains contested. Ramesh and his wife give permission to store earth at a specified edge for one week, under stated conditions; they have

not permanently consented to a road across the entire field. The press note explicitly records: “The first negotiation failed.”

Narrative Time, a Woman's Independent Signature, and Literary Evaluation

The chapter's chronology is not confined to a single day. After the morning negotiation and its failed outcome, passage 24 leaps forward “until Phagun of this year,” omitting several months. This is a significant long ellipsis in narrative time; within the omitted period, the limited footpath repairs are reported, but no water agreement is concluded. The seasonal change from a damp charcoal line at the opening to dry dust in Phagun is a verifiable element of the narrative's arrangement. “Fell through” in the title does not mean that a fully concluded agreement was subsequently cancelled: it means precisely that consent to the proposed agreement could not be obtained at the first negotiation.

Ramesh's wife questions the difference between “today's market price” and a valuation that includes women's labour in weeding the crop. In the public register, “loss zero” is not an absence of claims but an indication that payment made so far is zero. After her objection, claims and payments are entered in separate rows. Both wife and husband sign independently for the limited period of storing earth. The woman's statement is not simply an expression of support for her family; it creates a real condition of decision. At the Phagun fair, Farzana refuses a request to dance on the publicity stage and chooses to continue her trade at clearly stated prices. A communal celebration does not oblige every woman to become a cultural representative.

In narratological evaluation, “letter received” does not justify the inference “agreement approved”; “zero payment against loss” does not mean “zero loss”; and the word “emergency” establishes no unrestricted right of access everywhere. A transparent form becomes an instrument in the causal plot: signing a single misleading sentence could have changed real practices upon the land. The artistic achievement is to keep severe public debate alive through the damp charcoal line, a basket of okra, instruments tightened after repair, three varieties of bangles and the final image of a boat. Limitations remain. The characters often separate evidence, permission and debt entries with almost textbook precision, while the inner complexities of their opponents are less fully explored. Yet Jayaram's pressure to proclaim “success,” the impatience of members hoping for a culvert, and Ramesh's wife's urgency about buying medicine for her daughter expose the human stakes beneath the procedure.

Udyoga Parva / Kishkindha Kanda: Comprehensive Critical Assessment of Chapters 49–60

The Causal Movement from a Proposal for Cooperation to a Failed Agreement

The opening phase of the fifth parva (Chapters 49–52) presents unequal conditions of partnership through the price of cooperation, Sugriva's fear, Tara's reckoning and Angada's dissent. The middle phase (53–56), through Ruhani's key, collective work without a chief, the search for Mithun and medicine supplied in charity, develops limits upon institutional responsibility. The final four chapters (57–60) extend these finer divisions of rights into fields, floodplains, water committees, the envoy's journey and public negotiation. The causal progression can be identified precisely: from "we shall work together," to "whose work is being paid for, whose consent is involved, and who bears the risk," and finally to "unequal obligations must not be imposed on one another under the name of common agreement."

Yet the parva does not close with the story of a successful public agreement. Chapter 60's five conditions concern the work of a future process, not a fully executed contract. This incompleteness is consonant with the character of the Udyoga Parva: conditions of alliance, inequalities of power and the risks of an envoy become apparent before war or disaster. The resemblance to the Ramayana's Kishkindha Kanda lies in the difficulties of cooperation and search, but the caste, occupational and individual lives of modern characters cannot be made into a table of reincarnations of ancient figures. The end of the fifth parva signals the conditions imposed by Ganga in the coming Bhishma Parva: the cost of what a promise leaves unspoken remains to be tested.

Limits on Relations among Epic, Philosophy, and Evidence

The Janaka-time episode in Chapter 57, Hanuman's mission in Chapter 59 and Hanuman's brief return in Chapter 60 are clearly narrated components in two time strands. Chapter 58 contains no such independent ancient scene. It is mistaken to place all four chapters under one technique merely by calling them "two-time" narratives. The Udayana–Mimamsaka shastrartha of Chapter 54 is the philosophical centre of the fifth parva. The final four chapters turn instead to practical issues of evidentiary categories, verbal understanding and intended meaning, rather than a formally arranged philosophical debate. There may be a critical affinity between Bhamati's discussion of superimposition and the error of treating a form as though it were a person, but without a character actually uttering a specific formula from Bhamati this cannot be called a direct quotation from the

text. An orientation towards Tattvachintamani's account of valid knowledge is the critic's comparative instrument, not a doctrinal proclamation made by each of these four chapters.

Four tests matter in narratological application. First, direct physical signs have limits: a pole sinking or an old boat mark does not by itself establish land rights. Second, inference is subject to limiting conditions: results from two fields of seed trials do not guarantee a fixed yield over all land. Third, the intended meaning of words matters: the meanings of "open," "ber," "Badadari" and "Balthi" depend on speaker and context. Fourth, absence or non-availability: failure to find a person's name on a public list does not negate that person's existence, rights or dissent. The inferred use of classical terminology must be labelled as such. A literary narrative must not be treated as a legally authoritative code defining rights in contemporary government forms.

Social-Ecological Narrative and Annual Collective Events

Ramani Bind's makhana, Phoolmati Tiyar's nets, Dhani's irrigation, Ramesh's vegetables, Phoolo's betel leaves, Devaki's animal husbandry, Batohi's honey, Sabina's repair work, Nandini's nursery, Sushila's seeds, Dev and Ragini's music, Rekha and Suman's designs, Saroj's net-making, Malati's tap water, and the cultural businesses of Rashid, Ramesh Ghasi, Karun and Farzana all have distinct material tempos and economic values. Merely adding the names of "all castes and communities" is not enough. What is required is to show each kind of labour's causal effects, remuneration and right of refusal. The final four chapters succeed on several occasions by this criterion, yet many characters disappear from the page after making a single clearly articulated objection. Their long-term inner development cannot therefore be claimed on the basis of this section alone.

At the festival for opening the mouth of the channel, the measurement register is opened before the flag is raised; at the Phagun public recital the five conditions of the unsuccessful agreement are read aloud. This annual communal recurrence is not a fixed repetition of devotional ritual. It becomes a changing public performance of responsibility. Through a long temporal ellipsis, the intervening months before the folk recital are not related directly. The advantage of this compression is a continued focus on the principal conflict. Its limitation is that the reader sees too little of households' prolonged social responses to the failed agreement. When the novel repeatedly explains the ethics of putting names on paper, more space for silence, delay and uncertain behaviour could enrich the emotional effect.

Overall Achievements, Counterarguments, and Questions for the Next Parva

The fifth parva's achievement is not the celebration of a successful alliance, but the conversion of the difficult conditions for achieving consent into narrative. At the end of "The First Agreement Falls Through," nobody carries away a certificate of victory. Shabnam takes the five conditions in her boat to the opposite shore, a child's plate remains at Ramesh's home, and the public footpath and private bund remain separate issues. This incomplete outcome is narratively coherent. A counterargument is that almost every dispute about labour, ownership and distribution of information is met with repeated prescriptions to use "separate rows," "written objections" and "consent"; artistic variety is endangered. Yet no slip of paper can remove water by itself, fill someone's stomach or answer for damage suffered. This material incompleteness keeps the ideal of proper procedure under critical scrutiny.

In the coming Bhishma Parva, issues of Ganga, promises, hospitals, warnings and the distance between viewpoints will unfold. The principal research question emerging from the failed agreement of the Udyoga Parva is this: can written conditions actually protect people when warnings must be issued, and will arrangements for hearing those endangered first be effective? Answers can come only from the subsequent text; Chapters 49–60 do not establish the outcome.

Bhishma Parva / Sundara Kanda

Chapter 61 — Ganga's Condition

The Condition Begun Beside the River and the Distribution of Narrative Information

The chapter opens with footprints impressed in wet sand at a bend in the river far from Hastinapur. A slender stream enters the impressions and then recedes. Temporary footprints and the river's recurrent motion bring two orders of time together in this first scene. Shantanu asks Ganga her name; Ganga asks whether being told a name would enable him to know everything about a person. Here lies the narrative's subtle opening: to disclose an identity, to know an identity, and to acquire an unrestricted right to the truth about that person are not the same thing. Before marriage or life together, Ganga imposes the condition that he will not question her. Shantanu's initial attraction cannot adequately estimate the future cost of that condition. The wording of the condition is disclosed fully to the reader, but its cause is not immediately disclosed. Consequently, the reader's knowledge, the king's knowledge, and Ganga's knowledge proceed on three different levels.

The small scenes of meals in the palace, the maidservant's work, the lying-in chamber's clothes, and the king's touch prevent the condition from becoming merely a divine legend. Following the birth of the first child, Ganga's journey towards the river and the cessation of the infant's cry remain lodged in Shantanu's memory as fear. At the birth of the second child, fewer lamps burn; from the third to the seventh, the routines of royal administration continue, but the father's time is divided between a few days of touch and nights in an empty birth chamber. In this compressed duration, the narrative gathers years of births and deaths into a few passages. Yet the milk vessel, the chest of clothes, and the newborn's fingers create vivid scenic pauses within the summarising narration. Beyond counting events, we must attend to their experienced duration.

In the tenth passage, the narrator tells the reader the confidential story of the Vasus' curse, which Shantanu does not yet know. This is a decisive asymmetry of information. According to Ganga, a brief human life was a means of release from the curse; yet the narrator expressly insists that each child had a separate face and that the mother's fingers were left empty. Philosophical or mythological justification cannot erase bodily loss. It would therefore be mistaken to read the disclosure of a “divine cause” as resolving every ethical question surrounding the infants' deaths. The burden Ganga acknowledges and the burden of the silence endured by the

king are different. The narrative offers no modern judicial verdict concerning Ganga's offence; criticism must keep a clear distance between the mythologically narrated order of deeds and contemporary ethical judgement.

The Eighth Infant: Breaking a Promise or Beginning to Assume Responsibility?

At the birth of the eighth child, Shantanu presses his ear close enough to hear the newborn's heartbeat. Ganga walks towards the bank, and the king stops her explicitly for the first time: "Enough. Not this child." Outwardly, the event breaks a promise; inwardly, it transforms the father's assessment of the moral worth of his silence. Ganga herself says that Shantanu had the right to ask questions but surrendered it in exchange for the condition of his consent; now he has changed his decision. This raises a question about the permanence of rights and consent: is consent once given always irrevocable, especially when the life of a third person not previously known is affected? The novel does not confine the question to a single prescriptive sentence. It places together the living body of the child, Shantanu's delayed objection, and Ganga's exhaustion.

Ganga reveals the secret of the Vasus' curse but does not treat the grief over the dead infants as nullified by the language of scriptural liberation. She will take charge of the eighth child, Devavrata's education, and Shantanu will endure separation. The result is therefore not linear—"the king won and the condition lost." The eighth child's life is spared, but continuous life with both parents does not follow. Ganga carries the memory of seven infants; the king lives apart from his son. Following an ellipsis of many years, the young Devavrata appears practising how to arrest one current of the river with his arrows. Ganga brings him to his father. At that meeting Shantanu promises to say what he saw and not to present what he failed to understand as knowledge. Rather than classical omniscience, the scene establishes acknowledgement of the limits of experience as an ethical virtue.

At the palace gate Devavrata asks: what path is open to someone who was not consulted when the rule was made? That question prepares causally for Bhishma's vow and Amba's story. It is not a verbal prophecy but a preparation of the causes. Earlier Shantanu did not ask the reason for the condition; later his son asks how one may participate in making rules. If, in the next chapter, that same son makes an irrevocable vow affecting the lives of others, the lesson of the first chapter will be put to the test. Repetition of the language of promises does not mean repetition of meaning: circumstances change, and so does the ethical sphere of the promise.

Videhapur: The "Mithua" Slip and an Unproven Resemblance in the Search for Mithun

In the twenty-first passage, the story moves from the ancient river to a contemporary records room in Videhapur. On one side are the five conditions of the broken agreement in the Udyoga Parva; on the other are a wage register, a wet boat-fare slip, and the testimony of an elderly worker at the landing. The first document reads "Mithua," the second "Mi.," and in the third the witness remembers hearing "Mithu." Resemblance among the three does not prove that any refers to Lata's missing son Mithun. Mahesh insists that the names must not be joined; Naira asks permission before showing a private copy; Lata demands that nobody bring another person's child to her and call him Mithun. These actions establish the ethical foundation of the inquiry. Lata's hope does not make her an enemy of evidentiary limits; she herself refuses to turn away from possibilities contrary to her wishes.

Aditi arrives with the hospital's inventory records in a separate envelope and does not merge them with the search papers. Naira establishes three categories: letters actually seen, possible resemblance of names or sounds, and unverified guesses about personal identity. In narratological terms, this enacts the difference between perception and inference. "Mi." has been seen; "Mithun" has not been proved. Someone was heard saying "Mithu," but the speaker's face was not seen. The object supporting the evidence, its context, its date, and alternative possibilities must be examined separately. The original owner has not signed the old statement. This is reason to test the document's authenticity, not a final verdict that it is false.

Tara proposes adding private names to the public page of the agreement; Naira points out that permission to publish is absent. Yet Tara poses a legitimate counter-question: confidentiality about names must not become a means of suppressing wage arrears. An arrangement therefore begins to provide claim numbers, amounts due, and dates for replies to the original claimants without exposing their names publicly. Lata receives not the original photograph but a written description and a list of questions she may correct; a request is sent to verify the date on the boat slip. The search remains under way. Mithun has not been found; the identity of "Mithua" remains uncertain. The narrative's fidelity to truth depends upon precisely this unresolved conclusion.

Focalisation, Water Imagery, and the Critical Counterargument

Of the chapter's twenty-nine passages, the first twenty and two later passages belong to the ancient temporal stream, while the contemporary passages occupy numbers 21–26 and the final number 29. This is not conventional analepsis: the narrator constructs independent scenes in two

times. Focalisation shifts between Shantanu's fear, Ganga's concealed experience, Devavrata's curiosity, and Lata's grief-filled caution. The story of the Vasus' curse gives the reader an explanation before the king receives it; in the modern records room, the reader encounters unverified information alongside the characters. The differing distributions of information are a significant achievement of the narrative craft. From the perspective of rasa, the possibility of karuna arises from an infant's empty cradle and Mithun's clay horse; these objects are traces of feeling, not entries in an official inventory of emotions. The swelling river, footprints in sand, and soaked slip establish a recurring image: a line is made, but its permanence cannot be established.

There are critical limits as well. Because the psychological sequence of seven losses is rendered very briefly, the experienced complexities of Ganga's successive decisions merge at one point. The double chronology places the ancient condition and modern evidence in unusually explicit conceptual equivalence; Naira's three orderly headings may diminish the natural roughness of a living story. Nevertheless, Shantanu's and Ganga's distinct sorrows, Lata's hopeful dissent, and Tara's labour-related challenge to confidentiality prevent the section from becoming a single-track moral sermon. Its particular achievement is not to justify the condition but to make evidence of its consequences the centre of narrative judgement.

Chapter 62 — Bhishma's Vow

Inference About the Cause of Silence and the Unequal Cost of a Vow

The chapter begins in the palace courtyard with Devavrata loosening his bowstring while a bandage covers his scraped finger. The source of what follows is not a divine proclamation but his experience of his father Shantanu leaving his food untouched and the question he asks the charioteer. The charioteer tells him about the king's meeting with Satyavati. Devavrata is troubled, but he does not yet possess the whole truth about its cause. Seeing Shantanu's silence, he infers that his father suffers from an unfulfilled desire for marriage; on the strength of this inference he visits Satyavati's family. In the tenth passage, the story itself makes the king ask in return: what if the inference was wrong? This moment offers a severe self-criticism of the glorification of the vow. An irreversible answer made without adequate examination of the cause can become a crisis for the following generation.

At the landing, Satyavati bandages her younger brother's injured finger while her father counts the tokens of the day's transactions. A dynastic question from the epic enters the concrete body and economy of a

working household. Satyavati's father demands succession rights for her future children. Devavrata first publicly renounces the throne. But her father raises the prospect of claims by Devavrata's own future sons. The first condition concerns an individual's relinquishment of office; the risk posed by the next generation's succession is distinct. Devavrata therefore vows lifelong celibacy and renounces the possibility of children. It is essential to follow this causal enlargement of the oath. This is not simply one moment of "devotion to a father," but a decision that closes down numerous possibilities of life in the name of removing uncertainty about the future.

Alongside the ancient account's shower of flowers and the naming of "Bhishma," the author shows the injured finger of Satyavati's brother at the landing and the possibility of Devavrata's childless future. Divine praise, the written honour bestowed by the royal priest, and the individual's price are three different perspectives. Satyavati asks Bhishma explicitly whether he made the vow in her name or through his own judgement; Bhishma assumes the burden of his decision himself. Satyavati refuses to make the sacrifice the "price" of her marriage, because the resulting debt might in future become a social weapon against her and her children. She breaks the established role of woman as passive beneficiary. She also remembers the arrears for boats and nets at the landing: becoming queen does not, in her judgement, wipe out the actual wages owed to her family of origin.

The dialogue between king and son provides a second test of the decision. Shantanu had not demanded the vow; Bhishma acknowledges that he proceeded by inference, yet still wishes to own and uphold the decision. Having received the boon of choosing the moment of his death, Bhishma observes that choosing when to die is not the same as choosing every day of one's life. Thus the boon offered as a reward does not fully restore freedom. The distinction between control over the timing of death and the marital and familial possibilities of a lifetime is subtle. Criticism reads this boon not as a scriptural or historical fact, but as part of the novel's reconstruction of the Mahabharata narrative.

Satyavati's Pride in Labour and the Redistribution of Royal Authority

After arriving at the palace Satyavati wishes to draw water from the well herself, but an attendant tells her of the fear of punishment. Rather than expanding her control over her own hands, the station of queen restricts it. Conversely, the attendant's fear does not produce a simple story of one woman's oppression by another; it reveals the structure of punishment. Satyavati asks how many of the rules are written down and how many are obeyed out of fear. In a conversation in the garden she says that the justice of her decisions should be judged by her own work, not by a reckoning of Bhishma's sacrifice. Her voice brings together women's agency within the

royal household and the memory of an older riverside occupation. The author establishes no biological equivalence between Satyavati and the modern Ruhani or Tara: the intertextual relationship lies in the language of rights and the scenes of labour.

Through a long temporal ellipsis the births and childhood games of Chitrangada and Vichitravirya, Shantanu's death, the coronation of the first king, Chitrangada's death in battle against a Gandharva, and the young Vichitravirya's accession become one sequence. A little paper boat and a broken wooden bow are objects of remembrance: childish things bring the abstract vocabulary of royal succession into the embodied time of a household. Bhishma, on the one hand, advances the crown for another to wear; on the other, he demands accounts of responsibility in the use of the royal seal. Renouncing sovereign power is therefore not "complete absence from power." Through guardianship, teaching, and administrative oversight, Bhishma remains present in decisions of state. Criticism must make the contradiction explicit: refusing the throne and relinquishing all royal influence are not the same.

Satyavati's remaining question is: who will ask Vichitravirya's prospective wife about the marriage? Bhishma initially answers that the prince's wishes must be understood; Satyavati clarifies that the wishes of the woman he will marry matter too. When news arrives of the forthcoming journey to Kashi, ministers enumerate advantages for the great dynasties but cannot immediately answer the question of the princesses' consent. In a further domestic conversation Satyavati asks Bhishma whether, while keeping his own vow, he can still hear another person's right to choose. The chariot is prepared without the question being answered. This chapter thus establishes the concrete causal link to the next, "Amba's Time." The violence of the second chapter is not a sudden twist; it emerges from a warning already heard by Bhishma but not put into practice.

The Modern Agreement: Unequal Risks in "Open the Road First"

The contemporary scene in Videhapur enters with a new paper: the party on the opposite bank says that the road through the gate should be opened first, and compensation and safety inspection settled afterwards. Tara and Naira find Ramesh's dissent concerning his field in this one-sided proposal; it still appears on the original page. The abstract condition of "trust" distributes actual injuries differently, so the parties do not face equal risks. Mahesh obtains the source document for the "Mithua" register, but permission to examine the identity and handwriting is limited. Tara wants the numbers of labour claims, sums owed, and hearing dates delivered to the original claimants; publishing private names is not a necessary condition of doing so. Lata is told that the source of the register has been found, not Mithun's identity; she refuses to seize another person's child on

the strength of trust. Final outcome: the one-sided opening of the road is not authorised before discussion of safety inspection and compensation. This is not “an agreement accepted,” but a conditional rejection of the proposal.

In narrative time, the ancient royal story passes across many years, whereas the modern episode occupies only the few days required for papers to circulate. In the third person the narrator moves among Devavrata's predicament, Satyavati's doubts, and Naira's policy-minded caution. A significant critical strength is the refusal to declare the classical vow an unqualified virtue. A critical limit is that numerous ancient characters speak the remarkably explicit language of modern rules of authorisation. Whether this anachronism counts as a defect or a creative choice must be judged from the scenes: Satyavati's disagreement at the well unfolds as a natural episode of everyday life, while some exchanges at the royal court resemble modern institutional hearings. Distinguishing these two experiences is indispensable to assessing the writing.

Narrative Testing: Incomplete Reasons and the Meaning of a Promise

“The father does not eat his food” is directly experienced; “the father is unhappy because of my position as crown prince” is an inference. Adopting an irrevocable vow of celibacy before excluding alternative causes is a solution of unwarranted breadth. “Members of the court praise Bhishma” does not establish that “every future disagreement by Satyavati is unjustified.” “Approval by a collective committee” does not entail “permission to enter Ramesh's private field.” In the classical terms of the proposition, reason, and point to be established, the same objection applies to these different inferences: qualifying conditions, contrary evidence, and the rights of those affected have not been tested. A reading in relation to Bhamati's discussion of adhyasa, or superimposition, becomes possible where a promise is taken to mean someone's entire fidelity or a sacrifice to constitute a woman's entire worth. The novel does not, however, independently debate Bhamati's philosophical propositions here. Such a connection is the critic's construction of meaning, not a citation from the original treatise.

The chapter's achievement is neither the verdict “Bhishma is great” nor “Bhishma is wrong.” It turns the individual responsibility for a vow, the unequal social price arising from it, uncertainty about the future, and the scope of others' consent into questions. Visually, the scraped finger, boat tokens, bucket at the well, paper boat, and broken bow bring these controversies onto a human scale. The bowstring at the opening and the prepared chariot at the ending accelerate the sense of an impending

disaster, but the reader is not yet shown its consequences. The effectiveness of the chapter's narrative design rests on this incompleteness.

Chapter 63 — Amba's Time

The Stage of the Swayamvara and the Absence of Protection for Choice

The chapter opens with three brass plates in the palace at Kashi and Amba changing the fragrance of the flowers she has chosen. Her small desire to change flowers is accepted, but where is the authorised moment at which to declare the actual prior decision about a swayamvara? The ritual order prescribed by the priest offers no clear answer. The opposition between an aesthetically resonant object and institutional design is plain: outwardly the ceremony displays the right to choose one's own husband, yet armies, banners, and royal alliances transform its reality. Amba looks for Shalva's seat; Ambika and Ambalika have separate scenes of fear. In Vichitravirya's name, Bhishma takes all three sisters away in his chariot. Shalva resists and is defeated. Amba protests from the chariot that she came to give her own decision, not to hear somebody else's. This sentence matters because Amba does not become an agent in the plot only when she reaches the next court: her opposition is present during the original violence.

Arriving at Hastinapur, Amba requests a private meeting with Satyavati and identifies Shalva as the man she had already chosen. Bhishma admits he did not know this fact. “Not knowing” does not automatically preserve one's authority to give commands; Amba's counter-question names the epistemic error in his decision. Bhishma permits her to return to Shalva, but Shalva refuses marriage on the grounds of the “humiliation” of his defeat. Two independent causes operate here: Bhishma's abduction and Shalva's subsequent refusal. Amba explicitly rejects the argument that a king's defeat in battle has somehow become her consent. The defeated king chooses to safeguard his social standing and rejects the autonomous wish of the woman who had previously chosen him. The narrative refuses to gather all three events into the label “Amba's unsuccessful love.”

Again in the court at Hastinapur, Amba asks Vichitravirya and Bhishma whose duty it is to put matters right when the course of her life has been changed by decisions made by others. Bhishma invokes his vow of celibacy as a reason; Amba explains that she is not merely asking him to marry her —the larger question is responsibility. An offer of priestly refuge, donations, or protection may provide security of food, but it does not judicially settle the objection she has raised. Satyavati asks Amba what she wants and arranges for a copy of her statement. She does not call this limited action final justice. Feminist narratological reading must therefore

go beyond observing that "a woman has been given an opportunity to speak": it must also ask whether speaking brought any consequence in the domain of rights.

Three Knots: A Small Archive of Memory and the Separation of Causes

Having left the royal gate, Amba repeats her story in numerous hermitages, courts, and journeys. Society sometimes represents her as a woman defeated in love, at other times as an obstinate princess. An elderly ascetic woman makes her record the first day, her first conversation with Shalva, and the day of the swayamvara separately, creating a strip marked by three knots: first, her own choice; second, her forcible removal; third, Shalva's rejection. The object is simple; its methodological meaning is grave. Unless three events occurring at different times are distinguished, the responsibilities of different agents disappear. This is neither a modern police report nor an original historical document, but a memorial strip created by the novel inside its mythological temporal stream. Even so, comparison with the three incomplete slips of Videhapur is possible. On one side the three knots link three distinct and definite experiences; on the other three readings of "Mithua" do not establish the identity of an unknown person. The number "three" is the same, but its evidentiary work differs.

In Hotravahana's refuge Amba finds that her own name is sufficient. Her elderly grandfather suggests Parashurama's mediation but promises no victory. Parashurama listens to her account, investigates, and raises the question of Bhishma's responsibility. Amba rejects the proposal of compelling Shalva to marry her; she also refuses any settlement concluded in her name without permission. The armed struggle between teacher and pupil extends over many days, yet at its conclusion Bhishma is alive, the vow is unaltered, and Amba's demand for justice remains undecided. Being heard by a teacher is not inconsequential to Amba, but the power to fight a war and the power to deliver justice are different. Through this failure the chapter replaces the simple heroic rasa of revenge with the pathos of prolonged waiting and the basis for reflection.

The episodes of penance in the mountains and Shiva's boon are situated within the mythological age's world of belief. Amba herself does not regard the boon concerning a future birth as justice received in the present. The necessity of another lifetime is a terrible sign of the institutional constriction of the first. Giving the final strip to the elderly ascetic woman, she says her life was not simply a preparation for someone else's death; it was the time of her own wishes, taken away and then reclaimed through questioning. The novelist thus avoids making Amba merely a

prelude to Shikhandi's arrival. The next chapter will test Shikhandi's life on its own terms; the entire meaning of Amba's grief cannot dissolve into that arrival.

The Parallel Counterpoint in Videhapur: Mithun's Unproven Name and Lata's Consent

In the contemporary episode, someone reads the blurred lettering "Mithua" on the slip as another possible rendering of the name; several readings remain possible, but the date of the boat fare, age, and original ledger are still incomplete. Lata brings a knotted bundle of Mithun's old clothes and asks where her son is if three people read three different names. Naira cannot give a definite answer. While refusing to abandon the search, Lata repeats that she will not take another person's child on the strength of her grief. This is a decision of a woman's active judgement; she is not merely an object of karuna-rasa. Tara clarifies a line concerning the consent of those affected on the gate-agreement page. The change is not called a new, sixth condition: it makes consent explicit within the five existing conditions. The novel itself states that the Amba of the past and Lata of today were not witnesses for each other. Their similarity lies in the risk of writing a final decision about someone's life in that person's absence.

The chapter's arrangement of time is highly distinctive. In the ancient narrative, compressed ellipses carry us from a single day of the swayamvara through years of journeys, an extended war between teacher and pupil, penance, and the final question of a lifetime. In the contemporary narrative, a few meetings expand around the possible readings of one piece of paper. The plot moves at opposing speeds: the ancient, enormous span is compressed, while a minor inspection of a modern document is elaborated. Waiting produces different results in both time frames: Amba does not receive justice, and Lata does not find her son. It would be wrong to call this an equivalence in the magnitude of suffering. Amba's abduction and Mithun's disappearance differ in their causes, communities, periods, and agents.

Justice, Rasa, Focalisation, and the Limits of Composition

During Amba's scenes the focal consciousness chiefly follows the development of her attachment, fear, humiliation, resistance, and questions, although responses from Shalva, Satyavati, Bhishma, and Parashurama are also shown. The three knots are not based on three poetic resonances; they are an effective image of the classification of events. From the perspective of rasa, the anticipated celebration of marriage at the beginning gives way to the terror of war, then pathos, and finally the mixed experience of unfinished resistance. The author allows no single rasa

to become the final meaning of the entire sequence. A test of propriety or auchitya yields differing results: Satyavati's limited help is appropriate yet incomplete; Parashurama's war is impressive yet fruitless; Bhishma's promise is steadfast yet inadequate.

In a narratologically informed test of inference, Shalva's reason that "Bhishma won the war" is irrelevant to establishing Amba's consent. The reason "Bhishma is celibate" does not remove his partial responsibility. Nor does "the teacher fights a war" carry an unrestricted entailment that justice has been achieved. In the modern episode, any attempt to declare Mithua or Mithua's similar-sounding form identical with Mithun rests on an unreliable inference bounded by unexamined qualifications. This analysis claims no direct quotation from an actual treatise on narratology; it applies a method of examining evidence to the circumstances narrated.

The artistic achievement is that Amba's desire changes: beginning with the wish to share a life with Shalva, it grows into the larger question of who will write the story of her life. She corrects the meaning of her story herself. A limitation is that the elderly ascetic woman, Hotravahana, Parashurama, and Satyavati often speak in language resembling an explicit modern doctrine of consent and justice; the autonomous linguistic contradictions of the ancient period can consequently become less apparent. The recurrent experience of "the question was heard but justice was not given" risks slackening the pace. Yet the genuine exhaustion of Amba's journey and the recurring significance of the three knots provide partial artistic justification for that repetition.

Chapter 64 — Shikhandi's Decision

Repairing an Arrow and the Right of Self-Definition: From a Small Object to the Epic

The chapter begins with Shikhandi standing in the armoury, holding the broken tip of an arrow. The question—if its edge is intact, why not fit a new shaft?—turns away from the glamour of martial victory towards a craftsperson's inspection, the repair of a tool, and the testing of it. The narrator clearly separates what the royal family tells the outside world about Shikhandi's birth from what is suppressed within the palace. Shikhandi explains a defeat in training through errors in practice and tells their mother that they cannot wholly control what everybody calls them, but can exercise some control over what they learn. This opening does not manufacture a "predestined avenger" whose life has no initial significance beyond a dispute about birth identity. Repair, training, ointment for wounds, and consequential questions create the separate time of Shikhandi's own story.

From the story of Shiva's boon the royal family derives a political purpose for its child. Shikhandi asks: if my birth is an answer to an old injustice, then which days belong to me? The question establishes a sense of the limits of Amba's preceding story. The history of her suffering is not an exhaustive script for Shikhandi's subsequent life. A protagonist's self-understanding consists not merely in descriptions of the body but in a history of self-directed decisions. The chapter traverses a great chronological span—childhood, marriage, the meeting with a yaksha, relationships before battle, and Bhishma's fall—choosing a condensed succession of scenes to test different aspects of the character's autonomy.

Royal Secrecy, Inequality in Marriage, and Sthunakarna's Independent Will

Concerning the proposed marriage to the princess of Dasharna, Shikhandi first asks what she has been told about their life. After the wedding, the princess questions the decision made without informing her, and preparations for war begin to defend royal prestige. It would be wrong to call the conflict merely Shikhandi's "problem." The state maintains secrecy, restricts what the woman entering the marriage knows, and later converts its own supposed dishonour into material for war. Shikhandi's personal crisis and the princess's dissent need not be opposed interests; royal decisions exert different pressures on the rights of both. Shikhandi leaves the domain of royal commands and goes into the forest, where the yaksha Sthunakarna is encountered.

The exchange of female and male conditions in the ancient narrative is not treated by the novel as merely a marvellous miracle. Sthunakarna's explicit consent, the promise made for a limited time, and Shikhandi's duty to return are described in detail. The tale of the exchange becoming permanent because of Kubera's curse appears as a form of the ancient text; its cost falls differently upon the yaksha's body and life. To call this simply "Shikhandi's victory" would make the yaksha's involuntary, prolonged transformation invisible. Shikhandi promises to inquire after Sthunakarna. This narrative addition does not authorise making the mythological episode of bodily transformation into a universal metaphor for modern medicine or contemporary experiences of gender. Shikhandi's life, Sthunakarna's condition, and the consent of the daughter of the king of Dasharna remain independent questions.

Following a royal examination, the immediate threat of war diminishes, but the princess's original objection is not thereby resolved. Shikhandi offers her the choice of returning as she wishes; the princess decides to spend some time among her own people. Her letter asks for solitude, time, and the right to decide for herself. An agreement between royal houses is

not binding permission for marital life. This argument is one complicated consequence of Satyavati's warning in Chapter 62, but the narrator claims no historical verification. It belongs to a reconstructed Mahabharata temporal world.

Ruhani's Refusal: Criticism of Mythological Equivalence Within the Story

The first scene in Videhapur is an announcement for a school play: "Ruhani's Life: The Shikhandi of Today." Ruhani objects that Amba's story, Shikhandi's story, and their own modern life are three different lives, and that unthinking identification of all three for the sake of an easily grasped theatrical "example" is improper. The organiser promises a new title, but permission for rehearsals has not yet been granted. Later the poster changes to "Shikhandi: One's Own Promise, One's Own War." Even then a teacher insists on calling Ruhani the modern version, which Ruhani refuses again. Correcting a title and obtaining actual consent to representation are consequently two different outcomes. Ruhani agrees to examine the performance's language and the children's consent, but not to turn their personal life into evidence for a character.

During rehearsals a child asks whether Shikhandi only stood at the front or made an active decision. Rather than silencing the question, Ruhani has separate lists prepared for role, decision, and consequence. Intriguingly, the novel thus comments on a possible defect in its own intertextual criticism. If a critic makes Ruhani into "today's Shikhandi," adopting an easy metaphor, that critic violates Ruhani's explicit refusal within the text. This self-critical exchange marks the limit of the word "relationship" in a table of narrative connections: intertextual resonance is neither biological nor ethical equivalence between lives. As a matter of plot analysis, this is a relevant achievement in protecting the character's authority to narrate their own life.

Bhishma's Fall: Multiple Agents in Battle and the Incompleteness of Consequences

Before battle, Shikhandi takes responsibility for accounts of the army's food, evacuation of the wounded, chariots, horses, and arrows, rejecting the position of a single emblem of "Amba's revenge." Arjuna agrees on strategy but accepts responsibility for the arrows he himself shoots. Bhishma maintains his decision not to raise weapons against Shikhandi on the basis of an older belief. Within this triangle, military strategy, an individual's present capability, and an inflexible old promise are different purposes. On the tenth day Shikhandi advances and shoots arrows; Bhishma does not retaliate against Shikhandi. Arjuna's arrows inflict the

decisive injuries, and Bhishma falls upon the bed of arrows. The narrative's register of events keeps these four causal acts and responsibilities distinct. It would therefore be equally wrong to reduce Shikhandi to the sole "killer" or to a meaningless "shield."

On the battlefield soldiers attempt to proclaim victory under different single names. Shikhandi insists that the record contain what was seen: Shikhandi advanced from the chariot and shot arrows, Bhishma did not fire at Shikhandi, and Arjuna's arrows brought Bhishma down. Bhishma remains alive upon his bed of arrows; "Bhishma died" would be a false conclusion to draw from this chapter. Shikhandi has the names of wounded soldiers and the work of horses entered in the accounts and refuses to call Bhishma's fall complete justice for Amba's life. A battle narrative does not resolve every outcome: the living time of the bed of arrows and the coming war remain. This chapter gives a distant, altered resonance to the earlier conversation about Bhishma's power to choose his death in Chapter 62.

The Old Hospital Wing: Receipts, Place of Installation, and Safety

In the contemporary part, Raghav Singh brings a sample of wood, a rusted hinge, and three receipts. There is evidence that materials reached his firm's warehouse, but no verification of the specific room in which they were used. Lalit the carpenter explains differences in the load-bearing strength of the sample when wet and dry; Raghav promises laboratory certification but does not declare the whole wing's roof safe on the basis of one small piece. Aditi insists that source, date, and recipient's signature be recorded separately on the sample bag. Here is a sequence of physical proof: supply of material, installation in a particular place, load-bearing capacity under particular conditions, and safety for patients. Establishing the first fact does not automatically establish all four.

A young warehouse worker indicates that he may have seen or heard something, but does not yet give a complete eyewitness statement. Naira suggests that he record the time and place in his own words and distinguish firsthand from indirect information; Raghav tells him not to fill the blanks by guessing. In the evening Raghav applies his firm's seal only to the fact established by the receipt, not to the uncertain line about where the material was installed. Aditi identifies the need to check possible arrangements for moving patients safely and the inventory of tools. In the final passage Raghav's nephew points out a conflict between a date in an old account book and a signature on another page. Raghav promises to produce the original register the next day. The novel has not yet concluded that a signature is forged, that the roof is demonstrably unsafe, or that material was installed in the wrong room. The uncertainty has been entered in the record; the decisive inspection remains outstanding.

Nor has the “Mithua” slip become direct evidence concerning Mithun. The care taken with three possible readings, an incomplete date on the boat-fare slip, and the elderly witness's recollection continues the search begun in earlier chapters. Here the modern register becomes connected to a conditional comparison with the history of battle: several people contribute to an event, and recording only one name on paper does not truthfully erase the decisions or work of others. Yet an arrow in battle and evidence concerning a hospital hinge are not the same kind of proof. In one case the narrator constructs a battle scene; in the other the characters examine incomplete documents. Comparison is useful only when that difference is kept in view.

Focalisation, the Unnatural, and Impartial Evaluation

Across the chapter's twenty-nine passages, the long story from Shikhandi's childhood to the tenth day of Kurukshetra is conveyed through summary interrupted by expanded scenes, along with short contemporary sequences concerning the Videhapur play and the hospital investigation. The narrator separately presents the limited experiences of Shikhandi, the married princess, Sthunakarna, Ruhani, Raghav, Aditi, and the nephew. The mythological exchange of female and male states, Kubera's curse, and similar elements do not appear as direct evidence of modern physical science, but as the old supernatural rules of the story-world. The apparatus of postclassical “unnatural narrative” can be useful here under conditions: analysis must make explicit the difference between accepted rules within the narrative world and those of modern reality. Simply declaring an impossible scene a “delusion” would be a prejudgement.

The dominant resonance of these scenes is “the name of one's own deed”: repairing a broken arrow, Sthunakarna's consent, the princess of Dasharna's letter, Arjuna's separate arrows, Ruhani's self-description, and Raghav's limited seal. This plurality rewrites the Mahabharata's heroic account through individuals' right to speak for themselves and through structures of collective responsibility. Two limitations must be acknowledged. First, the story repeatedly lends its characters extraordinarily explicit modern language about rules of consent, potentially reducing the historical or mythological linguistic distance between Panchala and Hastinapur. Second, compressing the great events of war into a few passages gives relatively little room to the complexities of Shikhandi's actual fighting and the independent consciousness of other soldiers. Nevertheless, the wounded horse, charioteer, names of the soldiers, and Sthunakarna's own loss offer an alternative to a single-name heroic history.

The First Four Chapters of Bhishma Parva: Comparative Critical Conclusions

The Threefold Relationship Between Promise, Consent, and Consequence

In Chapter 61 Shantanu accepts Ganga's condition without knowing its full consequences; the courage to question her over the eighth infant changes the value of his silence. In Chapter 62 Devavrata makes an irrevocable vow on the basis of an uncertain inference about his father's silence; Satyavati refuses to record that sacrifice as a debt owed for the price of her marriage. In Chapter 63 Bhishma's vow is not an adequate answer to Amba's question about responsibility: Amba distinguishes the three events and the costs of several decisions. In Chapter 64 Shikhandi insists on acknowledging Sthunakarna's conditions, the wishes of the daughter of the king of Dasharna, Arjuna's separate actions in battle, and the independent sphere of Ruhani's life. Across this progression, the initial rule of a condition becomes an ultimately inadequate guarantee for personal life. The final ethical test is not the firmness of words but the independent decisions of the people affected and the actual distribution of consequences.

The Distributed System of Narrative Time and Focalisation

The Ganga episode uses ellipses spanning several births and the growth of a young man; Bhishma's vow compresses several royal generations; Amba's story follows the pursuit of justice over a lifetime; and Shikhandi's narrative extends from childhood to the tenth day of battle. The contemporary line in Videhapur converts a much shorter span into the stubborn waiting imposed by files, meetings, and prospective inspections. These opposite speeds create a structural tension: decades of ancient lives pass rapidly in narration, while the ambiguous wording of a single modern receipt receives slow investigation. Comparing these tempos reveals two different sources of the novel's epic scope and its detailed social attention to evidence. But excessive use of the pattern “new paper, another line, unanswered question” threatens to retard movement. Amba's knots in Chapter 63 and the broken arrow in Chapter 64 give a human rhythm to this procedure.

The narrator is not permanently confined to any one character's private knowledge. In Chapter 61 the reader learns the account of Ganga's curse before the king does, while in the modern search the reader is also deprived of a confirmed identity. In Chapter 62 the king himself frames a question that answers the prince's inner inference. Amba's long experience becomes the principal focal centre of Chapter 63; Shikhandi's autonomy is

particularly explicit in Chapter 64, although Sthunakarna's and the princess's choices receive their own scenes. This distributed perspective gives the narrative an ethical voice different from the royal history of a single man. Nevertheless, the narrator sometimes organises the characters' utterances too neatly in order to explain a predetermined concept; it is fair to call this partially didactic.

The Limits of Applying Indian Poetics, Narratology, and Videha's Parallel History

The possibility of karuna-rasa is dispersed across Ganga's empty cradle, Shantanu's touch, Amba's extended journey, and Lata's knot of clothes. The energy of vira appears in Shikhandi's decisions and Bhishma's military skill; the marvellous, adbhuta, in the curse on the Vasus, the shower of flowers, and the mythological exchange involving Sthunakarna. Yet merely identifying signs of rasa is not a critical evaluation. Dhvani suggests that omitted names, the broken bow, the soaked slip, and the debt borne by the yaksha's body point beyond the overt action to larger questions of life. From the standpoint of auchitya, or appropriateness, serious literary judgement—not an easy endorsement of consent—is required to decide how natural the terminology of contemporary rules sounds when placed in the mouths of ancient characters.

In the narrative analysis, consent, reason, entailment, qualifying conditions, direct perception, and the comprehension of verbal testimony have been used as critical instruments. No sentences purporting to reproduce the original verses of Tattvachintamani or Nyayakusumanjali have been invented for the characters' dialogue. Resemblance in readings of “Mithua” does not establish Mithun's identity; evidence of the arrival of Raghav's material does not prove the hospital roof safe; steadfastness in Bhishma's promise does not cancel Amba's wish; Shikhandi's presence on the battlefield does not erase the fact of Arjuna's arrows. The examples belong to different kinds of evidence, but the methodological caution is one: do not artificially stretch a reason beyond what it establishes. Bhamati's metaphor of superimposition is sometimes useful in explaining confusion between a name and a person, or between a promise and justice. The metaphor cannot be declared a fully equivalent doctrine of Shankara's Vedanta.

Using Videha's parallel-history method, the official memory of royal dynasties and battle can be read alongside maidservants, midwives, the injured finger of a boatman's brother, a woman's knotted strip, a smith's arrow, the care of horses, a hospital's porter, and outstanding wages. But parallel history does not mean treating every sentence of mythological imagination as a historical record of ancient society. The epic scenes

rewritten by the author are evidence of social imagination and proposals for criticism; papers in modern Videhapur are documents within the story-world; independently confirming external social history is the task of different research. These three levels must remain distinct.

Continuity of Evidence for the Story Ahead

By the ends of the four chapters, the established outcomes are these: Devavrata has declared his vow; Amba's independent search for justice has not succeeded; Shikhandi participated in the strategic battle, Arjuna's arrows brought Bhishma onto the bed of arrows, and Bhishma remains alive. In the modern story the gate has not been completely opened and Ramesh's objection still stands; the name "Mithua" has not been proved to identify Mithun; receipts establish that hospital materials were delivered, but their place of use and the roof's load-bearing safety remain unverified; Raghav's nephew proposes producing the original register the following day. These verification points must be carried into a permanent register of narrative continuity from Chapter 65 onwards. Mechanical signals of change cannot take the place of such outcomes.

Chapter 65 — The Old Hospital Wing

Water Dripping into a Bowl: The Scale of an Event and Uncertainty About Its Cause

The chapter opens with a small drop falling from the roof of the old hospital wing. A woman cleaner places a bowl beneath it and returns to work; Salma sees the risk of slipping and puts up a yellow warning marker. The scale of the outward event seems trivial, but the gradual filling of the bowl brings medical care, wages, the history of a building, and the responsibilities of the municipal administration together. The roof is wet; it is not known whether the leak originates in a pipe, a joint, or external drainage. "Water is dripping" is direct observation; "that particular pipe is at fault" is inference. The distinction is established in the first passage. The craft of the opening is to place the reader amid an immediate and genuine risk without staging a dramatic collapse of the building. The bowl's appearances at the beginning and end establish a circular image, but even at the end the cause of the leak is not identified. Initially the object arouses fear; when it reappears, it recalls the institution's limited containment of the danger and the incompleteness that remains.

Shital Devi's treatment tube, swollen feet, and wish to walk create a real tension between the patient's self-determination and the medical constraints of her body. Saying "I can walk" expresses an individual wish, not evidence that transfer would be safe. Aniruddha discovers that half of

the western staircase shown as broad on the hospital plan has become a storeroom for medicine cartons. Alongside counting twelve beds, he prepares separate lists of equipment, continuous treatments, and people requiring the help of two members of staff. The site plan, the current physical route, and the requirements of treatment become three parallel registers. An empty room is not synonymous with an available place for treatment. Salma keeps details concerning two patients requiring breathing support, an elderly person receiving continuing treatment, and a mother who wishes to stay beside her child on a closed medical sheet. The distinction between this confidential list and the public one protects patients' rights to their identities without dissolving the hospital's responsibility.

The Chain of Material Evidence and Labour's Embodied Knowledge

In the fifth passage Aditi herself begins to regard her earlier estimate of a "minor defect in the repair" as inadequate. Rather than erasing the old line, she decides to record a dated correction. Scientific credibility here does not consist in the first estimate never being wrong, but in the practice of leaving the history of error visible. Raghav's nephew fears signing a declaration concerning the handling of materials he did not see. Raghav himself prevents him from inventing an eyewitness account for the firm's benefit. But the young man's complete and safe statement has not yet been secured; it would be illogical to treat his silence as an admission of fault. Two pieces repaired by Meena Sah, the warehouse receipt stamped upon arrival, and an official letter marked "work completed" are three separate evidentiary objects. The third document leaves the location of use blank. There is no automatic entailment among the three propositions that an item was received, that it was installed, and that the building became safe. Here the novel's method of evidence grows out of concrete and visible objects; it does not require philosophical terminology imposed from above.

Gomati acknowledges from bodily experience that she carried a sack, but does not know whether it held lime or another mixture or where the contents were used. Her back can testify to weight, not to the chemical quality of construction material. Lalit the carpenter's refusal to certify load-bearing safety merely from looking at a sloping board is an active decision of professional ethics. He has previously paid its economic cost by losing a contract. An empty bed catches at the bend of the old staircase; this is a site test, not a successful complete evacuation drill with a patient, equipment, and staff. In these scenes craftspeople's caution is not an adversary of administrative expertise but its indispensable partner. From the perspective of narrative time, a four-year-old bill, an old sack, a previously blocked sloping board, and the current evacuation converge;

earlier periods are made present through papers, rather than independent scenes of an ancient epic. To apply "dual chronology" literally to this chapter's design would therefore be mistaken.

The washing drain, hand-washing, roof leakage, and an outside pit form a network of four possible sources. Meena trusts her inherited recollections concerning shells and lime, but insists that folk memory must not be substituted for testing the materials. Aditi's independent laboratory request turns the novel's discrimination between inferences into institutional action at this point. Nor do Tara's and Hira's measurements of water establish the entirety of the wall's defect. The river and hospital are not merely similar as symbols: the physical relationship of drainage is something to be examined. For hydro-environmental narratology the distinction matters. Water is not scenery but an active circumstance affecting treatment, safe routes, wages, and structural risks; nevertheless it has not been declared the culprit before the cause is demonstrated.

Moving Patients: Incomplete Success and the Redistribution of Work

Jamuna Devi is grateful to the hospital that saved her life, but also demands an examination of the old wall and safety for Shital. Receiving care does not extinguish the right to criticise it. At a municipal meeting, the proposal to write "all patients transferred" and lock the wing exposes a gulf between a verbal order and continuing treatment. Aniruddha has three categories prepared: those who can remain with lower risk for the present, those who should move as soon as trained arrangements are available, and those needing immediate priority. The public notice contains numbers and arrangements; the private file contains names. This classification must not be mistaken for a general policy list that replaces final medical judgements: the condition of every bed requires review.

Shital is transferred to the new wing once equipment and a trained team become available; her questions are heard and the handover recorded. This is the chapter's established positive outcome. But arrangements for the remaining elderly patient are incomplete. Temporary monitoring and an emergency plan are retained, and pressure for immediate removal is resisted. "One patient has been moved" does not mean "the whole wing is empty." Urmila's two additional trips with special laundry make the unexpressed price of safety visible. Calling it "help during an emergency" does not render her extra hours free. Salma adds the carrying time to the order, but final payment is not settled. Meena receives a separate acknowledgement of the wages due; payment remains outstanding. Videha's parallel-history perspective is especially pertinent here: the hospital's official story of "repairs" would remain incomplete if written without workers' backs, washing hours, risks borne by cloth, and the craftsperson's missing signature.

Narrative Organisation, Rasa, and Critical Limitations

The chapter can be read in four stages: the identification of risk in the opening scene; the confrontation of several kinds of evidence about materials and evacuation (passages 6–20); Shital's actual transfer and the recalculation of wages (21–24); and the revised report and the still unresolved safety of the remaining patient (25–30). Its narrated scenes principally take place within one day; earlier time returns in documentary form through old bills and work slips. Focalisation shifts between Salma's sensitive nursing, Aditi's judicious testing, Aniruddha's assessment of the risks of treatment, Urmila's wages, and Meena's professional self-defence. The omniscient narrator indicates the limits of many people's knowledge without granting any of them a complete answer. Shital seated upon her bed and the elderly patient form the centre of karuna; the bowl, yellow marker, and safe handover express the feeling of quiet discipline.

Its achievement is to make "inspection" an act of narrative. Its limitation is equally clear: numerous characters explain the same principle of perception, inference, and confirmation in separate speeches, sometimes making dialogue resemble a technical hearing rather than spontaneous emotion. The language with which Meena, Gomati, Lalit, Tara, Aditi, and Naira distinguish kinds of evidence is substantially alike. Their occupational imagery differs, but their voices and intellectual formations might have been differentiated more strongly. Yet Urmila's meal break, Shital's slippers, and Jamuna's medicine keep the conceptual prose tethered to the inconveniences of actual life. The critical conclusion is exact: hospital safety measures have begun, one safe transfer is complete, and a fuller investigation has been declared necessary. The final cause of the construction fault, the full evacuation of the remaining patients, and settlement of the workers' wage arrears have not been achieved.

Chapter 66 — The Pause of Krishna and Arjuna

From the Written Order to the Ancient Pause at Kurukshetra: Rearranging Narrative Time

The first scene takes place at half past five in the morning: the hospital's yellow warning tape and Urmila's halted laundry trolley. The guard displays a page ordering the wing to be "completely evacuated at once," although Aniruddha's medical decision the previous evening made some transfers dependent on the availability of a trained team and equipment. This discrepancy prompts Naira's first question: does the wording of an order describe an event that has actually occurred, or pronounce that it has occurred? An employee wants the dispute closed by applying a seal, but the false appearance of "completion" cannot be accepted without

acknowledging the risks. The sentence on the paper runs ahead of the real state of events in time. At that moment the storyteller abruptly changes temporal levels: at dawn as the war is about to begin at Kurukshetra, Arjuna stops his chariot between the two armies. The reader has already witnessed Bhishma's fall in an earlier chapter, but the narrative now returns to the moment when war begins. The novel marks this reversal of chronology explicitly; it should therefore be understood not as a lapse of attention but as a deliberate repositioning.

Arjuna sees the banners first, then beneath them the bodies of Bhishma, Drona, his brothers and relatives, and unnamed young soldiers. A banner marks a royal side; the human body beneath it bears the cost of war. An anonymous charioteer's soothing of a horse extends focalisation beyond the hero to a nonheroic figure. In dialogue with Krishna, compassion versus inaction, conceptions of body and self versus the cries of the wounded, action without desire for reward versus responsibility for consequences, and one's own duty versus an unexamined role arise in sequence. The novel employs the episode not as a word-for-word translation of the Sanskrit Gita or Mahabharata, but as a reconstructed, fictional classical scene for modern ethical reflection. To treat the wording of Krishna's and Arjuna's speeches as direct scriptural quotations from the original Gita would therefore be an error of textual criticism.

Duty, Compassion, and Consequence: The Achievement of Philosophical Rereading

Arjuna's hesitation cannot be explained simply as personal fear of Bhishma. His experience holds questions concerning his teacher, grandfather, the families that will survive the war, and the dead on all sides. Krishna argues that if compassion stops every act of decision, the future passes into the hands of other, uncontrolled powers. Arjuna asks in return whether “detachment from the fruits of action” can become leave to evade responsibility for outcomes. Krishna explicitly denies that possibility. The novel's ethical centre is not the simple maxim “perform your duty, whatever the result,” but action undertaken together with responsibility for decisions. One critical question follows: are the heterogeneous philosophical dimensions of the ancient Gita being compressed too far into the language of modern administrative accountability? The author tries to keep the disagreement alive among body and self, attachment and discernment, character and role, and disinterested action. Yet the subtler differences between Krishna's modern statements of responsibility and the classical source traditions require separate examination; the novel is not their definitive scriptural exegesis.

Arjuna also recalls Shikhandi's independent judgement, and Krishna does not claim to speak as that warrior's representative. This small moment establishes a dialogue with the preceding chapter of Bhishma Parva. Since Shikhandi has insisted on ownership of the name of their own actions, neither Arjuna nor Krishna can speak in their place. Before celebrating the lifting of his bow as heroic, Arjuna accepts responsibility, including the possibility of making mistakes with consequences. But the reader must be careful: this chapter does not claim to have justified all the violence of the war at Kurukshetra. Its narrative organisation presents an argument in the form of questions, not an invincible theorem of history.

A "Fragment" of Dharma Is Not Evidence for Hospital Policy

Back in contemporary Videhapur, a young man shows a sentence about war on his phone to defend forcibly removing a patient. Naira identifies an inadequate reason connecting a "fragment" of scriptural quotation with an authoritative hospital order. Aniruddha does not minimise the danger, but opposes unplugging equipment and pushing patients out; Salma distinguishes trained emergency evacuation from coercive suppression of dissent. Three documents—visible risk, the clinical list for patient transfers, and the official's authority—cannot all be certified by the same stamp. Eventually the "fully evacuated" order is rewritten: restrict access to the immediately dangerous part, ensure continuity of treatment during phased transfers, provide a trained team, inform families, and name the official to whom objections may be made. The term "by force" is removed. This is a definite and measurable administrative change. Yet the hospital has not become safe overnight, and medical transfers of the remaining patients are still proceeding. This distinction is the actual state of the plot's outcome.

The arrival of a new character, Devi Gond, tests the wider argument at the smaller scales of institution and home. On the first day of training, her name is missing from the deployment register and she is stopped at the entrance. After the centre's stamp and the trainer's presence have been checked, she is assigned to count clean supplies under supervision. Devi makes clear that she is not a doctor but is in training. This acknowledgement of her limitations protects a patient's family from false reassurance. A receipt for twelve dressing packets, two sealed boxes, and three hours of practice documents what she has learned; approval of payment for additional carrying work is separate. At home, proposals to arrange care for her mother and divide the time with her brother do not immediately create full equality, but Devi does not sign the document withdrawing from her training. Her agency in work is not a modern counterpart to Arjuna's decision in war: it is her particular economic and familial struggle.

The “Mithua” slip, the incomplete date of the boat fare, and a voice once heard by an elderly person return in the search for Mithun. Without comparing all three sources Naira refuses to announce that a particular child has been found. Lata permits necessary information for the search to be made public, but not her private, emotional words. Two blows on iron sound from a distant landing; Naira will not record Mahesh's speculation concerning the gate without seeing its source. This final uncertainty of hearing forms the causal thread to the next chapter. One part of the narrative closes with the correction of the hospital's false order; another opens to investigate unwarranted certainty about a sound that has merely been heard.

Narrative Frequency, Rasa, and the Artistic Worth of Disagreement

The chapter has three clearly defined temporal organisations: the hospital at dawn (passages 1–2), an extended scene in the ancient period before the war (3–14), and the modern sequence from dawn through noon and evening to night (15–32). Reasoned dialogue expands scenic time in the ancient section; the modern section spans the moderate durations of a committee's decision, Devi's training, a household dispute, and the search for Mithun. Karuna and heroism do not become opposing rasas: Arjuna's slack bowstring and the frightened voice of an elderly patient both insist on the necessity of considered action. The principal achievement is to show that refraining from a decision also produces consequences, but a decision requires accounting for the lives of those affected beforehand. Its critical limitation is that Krishna, Naira, Aniruddha, and Devi make extremely orderly arguments that sometimes sound as clear-cut as a modern policy document; the conflict of ethical complexity is already arranged towards resolution within the dialogue. Nevertheless, Devi's mother, Shital's bedding, the young man who has put down a stone, and the unverified source of the metallic clang keep obstruction, exhaustion, and the realities of embodied life within the narrative.

Chapter 67 — Seeing from Afar

The Institutional Violence of Calling What Was Heard "Seen"

The chapter opens at the tea stall near the railway square, with the morning's first kettle and the wet tip of Fakira's walking stick. In a single sentence Fakira establishes its central problem: to be present in a particular direction and to see an event are not the same thing. The previous night he heard two distant metallic clangs; his inference concerning the lock on Mahesh's gate was not a source-verified fact. Yet the public notice, issued in Fakira's name, declares that he "saw two persons breaking the gate." The decisive event is not the distant sound but the documentary procedure by which an auditory experience is converted into eyewitness testimony. This is more than a correction of vocabulary: that conversion raises both the prospect of a public accusation against unidentified perpetrators and the question of a labouring witness's credibility. Fakira retains the original copy of the notice and permits Naira to record its number and seal. This small consent grows out of his earlier administrative experience with a travel pass: official custody of paper does not, by itself, guarantee its safe return.

Fakira distinguishes three registers of experience in recounting his nocturnal route, the loose brick, the vibration transmitted through the tip of his stick, and the clang in the distance: hearing, touch and inference. His recollection of the direction of the wind is not a precise measurement of the sound's origin; the privately experienced distance of a dark path is not a distance measured with a tape. These distinctions allow a general critical application of "contact between a sense and its object" in assessing narrative perception, but no inference can be declared authoritative without external verification of its source. It would also be wrong to grant Fakira an omniscient sense of hearing merely on the basis of the account of his blindness or physical limitations of sight. He himself specifies the limits of what his ears tell him; his achievement is not supernatural perception but discipline in identifying sources.

Sound Tests, Site Measurements and the Four Boxes in the Register

Safe access to the lane is arranged before the examination begins. Tara explains the distance to the railway track, while Fakira sets his own pace: helping a witness reach the site is not an act of charity but a condition of making the inquiry possible. Looking at an old photograph of the crack, Aditi asks what evidence establishes that the crack appeared on the night the sound was heard. A security assistant deliberately strikes an iron strip twice and asks Fakira whether the sound matches. Fakira distinguishes near from distant sound and immediately refuses to identify the noise. If

an improvised demonstration plants an expected answer in the witness's memory, it is not a test but contamination of evidence. Aditi's objection gives that methodological danger narrative form. The loose metal strip in the lane, Raghav's old delivery voucher and Meena's account of a different metal vessel together suggest a possible reconstruction, but no independent basis permits the three to be treated as the same object. The causal sequence joining the two sounds to the external crack remains under investigation.

A woman living near the watchman's quarters also heard the clang, but cannot specify the interval because rain was falling and she was putting a child to sleep. She does not want her household's full name in the public notice. Two witnesses' uncertain experiences can support one another without automatically supplying the details missing from each account. The official form has a box for "seen" and none for "heard"; Fakira refuses to mistake a defect in the form for a defect in his experience. At his insistence, the revised statement has four explicit sections: heard, touched, subsequently heard from someone else, and inferred. This arrangement lets the reader see how narration itself produces categories of evidence. When the shape of an investigative document is wrong, it can turn genuine testimony into an administrative falsehood. In the modern narrative the form is an instrument of linguistic power, not a neutral set of empty compartments.

The Actual Result of Correction, Incomplete Civil Rights and Economic Time

The erroneous entry recording Fakira as dead on his travel pass has still not been corrected. One employee hints that disputing the testimony could affect the pass correction; Fakira rejects the conflation of two distinct procedures for securing rights. The purpose of the hint has not been established: Naira records the words without alleging an intention unsupported by further evidence. In the original register, "night, two sounds" is followed by the addition "two men, gate." The handwriting appears different, but neither the person who made the addition nor the person who ordered it has been identified. The following day, the register arrives with an amendment: the earlier public account did not match the witness's statement, and the assertion of eyewitness testimony is withdrawn. This chapter's demonstrable administrative achievement is the correction of the false claim that Fakira saw the event. The cause of the nocturnal sounds, possible perpetrators, correction of his travel pass and payment of his attendance allowance all remain unsettled. The decision to retain the original, historically erroneous page makes accountability visible instead of erasing the history of the mistake.

Fakira cannot afford to lose the earnings from delivering his bundle merely because he has been obliged to remain available as a witness from morning until evening. His further demands—that hearing times be specified beforehand, details of his private residence not be published, and travel expenses be covered by a written allowance—expose the concealed costs of producing evidence. An allowance slip is prepared, but payment has not been authorised. Thus "giving someone a voice" in the novel is not simply an ethical freedom: to be heard requires time, travel, livelihood, reputation and safe access. Asked about religious and social classifications of working people, Fakira replies that a register might describe him as "Sai Fakir" or "Diwan Madar," but neither expression exhausts his identity. The relevance of historical community names is not denied; it is the presumption that a name can encompass an entire person which is challenged. Here the tangible basis for a Videha Parallel History reading is the voice of a witness, relegated to the margins of official accounts, who insists on defining the value of his own participation.

The Recurrence of a Distant Sound: Rasa, Narrative Time and Credibility

The previous night's two clangs return in three forms: Fakira's recollected testimony, the artificial nearby demonstration, and two different noises produced by the wheels of a hospital stretcher. The number of sounds is the same; their sources are not. At the end, Fakira hears several more distant clangs but, rather than appointing himself a guard over conjecture, resumes his own journey. The function of this recurrence is not to turn the mystery of a supposedly broken gate into an inevitable crime thriller; it shows the disjunction between memory, a printed notice and external events. Sarita's bowl of lentils, a child's lesson and the coins of a day's earnings generate an inward pathos, but Fakira is not merely a suffering character. His laughter, bargaining and precise rebuttals establish his independent personhood. Through Fakira's inner dignity the narrator criticises the public deformation of testimony. Naira's supporting role matters, but the primary demand for correction comes from Fakira himself.

One limitation is that the four categories of evidence are organised with a notably pedagogical clarity; in actual conversation, such verbal distinctions may be more closely entangled. Another is the repeated invocation of hearing, touch and inference in several scenes, which risks slowing the narrative. Yet the time demanded by an itinerant livelihood, the hospital stretcher and Sarita's domestic conversation give this instructional repetition the texture of many lives. The unresolved correction of Fakira's death entry reappears at the close: verifying one document does not automatically repair a different injustice.

Chapter 68 — A Copy of the Warning

The Original Warning and the Textual Divergence of Its Abridged Summary

When the knot of red thread binding an old file comes undone, Aditi lays it on a separate sheet of paper, counts the pages and examines the original once more. In this opening the physical procedure of preservation is itself an event: old paper is not merely information, for its conservation and sequence may retain traces of who was entrusted with it. Three sheets emerge from the file: an inspection signed by Aditi, an office summary and an amended copy of uncertain provenance. The original inspection requires "mandatory reinspection after the rains"; the summary replaces that condition with a general suggestion for repairs. The omission of a few words erases a duty directed towards future risk. From the reader's perspective, the decisive "event" of the chapter is not a collapsing wall but an active warning converted into passive description.

The serial number for receipt between the two dates has disappeared, and nobody knows who composed the summary. Aditi acknowledges that calling the crack "small" in the first inspection exceeded the adequacy of her measurements, because full equipment was unavailable. Although she had required reinspection, she also reproaches herself for not insisting strongly enough on proof of the later, complete examination. Such self-criticism is not an immediate confession of crime; it is a conscious review of incomplete professional responsibility. The repair voucher for the hospital's old loading ramp and Aditi's warning about foundation drainage are separate documents. An unsigned box for reinspection does not establish that reinspection never took place; the missing paperwork raises a legitimate question about the institution's search. At a general level of narrative reasoning one can draw from this event the difference between "no proof has been found" and "the event never occurred." The novel does not present that formulation as a literal quotation from a foundational philosophical text.

The Landscape of the Old Channel: Three Questions and Three Methods of Proof

Following the file's trail, Tara, Naira and Ratan reach the outside of the enclosure at Purnadhar in the forest. Because the warehouse boundary is disputed, Tara decides to use temporary markers rather than drive stakes into the earth. Ratan shows "the old course of the Jibach" in his father's papers. He describes standing water after the rains as he remembers it from childhood, but does not claim that this proves the river's entire present flow. The warehouse accountant raises questions about workers' sacks,

freight and daily wages; Ratan accepts that any investigation of the watercourse must reckon with these livelihoods. The conflict is not a simple opposition of "ancient truth of water" to "new plunderers" but an interdependence between the land's history and labour in the present.

Tara separates three questions: where the old drainage route lay; what the soil and water actually do today; and what current ownership the revenue records recognise. The first calls for memory and old maps, the second for technical measurements and the third for legally relevant records. Their regimes of proof cannot be substituted for one another. The knotted cord in Ratan's father's possession is a material trace of local history, not a standardised measuring instrument. He retains the original paper; private field names are cropped out of the limited photographs; and the sewing hours forfeited by the young woman who helps read and write the documents are acknowledged as payable labour. There is a concrete basis here for describing a parallel history of evidence: the father's local measuring cord, an elder's remembered route and a woman's literate labour become preliminary evidence alongside the revenue and engineering files, without automatically replacing a legal determination.

Field Examination, Uncertain Water Causation and Historical Debt

Because the warehouse wall itself may have shifted, measurements begin at a stable stone on the public path. The depths to soft mud and to the firm layer beneath are measured separately. Sample collection is postponed because laboratory serial numbers and the method of collecting samples have not yet been agreed. This postponement is not merely mechanical bureaucracy: improper collection may destroy the future evidentiary value of the material. The presence of a warehouse representative and a witness familiar with the local route is accepted, but technical sampling is left to a trained team. The elderly Ratan does not enter by the old path because of thorns and wire. A sense of ownership derived from memory confers no exemption from present physical danger. The worker's experience of "not seeing a river for ten years" does not falsify Ratan's older childhood memory; their periods of observation are different. To force experiences of differing durations into a single "is or is not" question would be an elementary error of temporal-spatial analysis.

The name "Dhemura" appears on Suraj Gangota's debt paper, but it is not joined to the old line of the "Jibach" to declare a single geographical confluence. The son's ethical and economic question—why a debt outlived the field it helped destroy—is an independent claim; the original debt register must still be requested. In narrative arrangement, watercourse and debt open up the possibility of an intimate connection: old memories of flooding extend the social lifespan of an obligation. They do not, without geographic facts, settle the law of debt relief. News of a stronger smell of

water in the hospital corridor brings this field examination into immediate contact with patient safety; the inspection team and treatment team have separate duties. A common survey of ground levels is proposed, but the warehouse's waterlogging is not yet a proven cause of the hospital damage.

The Language of Warning, Levels of Knowledge and the Novel's Ethical Craft

The assistant engineer questions Aditi about the old phrase "small crack"; Aditi again shows the actual wording of the original warning. Naira refuses to report that "past negligence has been proved" and separates three findings: the original warning was recorded; an essential clause was omitted from the summary; and the result of reinspection remains to be located. Together, these do not establish an entire chain of fault, motive and resulting harm. At night Aditi finds that a "local estimate" in the preliminary calculation has become a "measurement" in the later summary. The divergence between documents thus has two levels: removal of a duty to act upon a warning and promotion of an estimate into measured fact. The decision to preserve the original and amended documents makes textual criticism an internal method of the narrative. Deleting the error would not correct it; it would erase its history.

The security team's draft states that "illegal filling at the warehouse caused the hospital damage." Naira changes it to "a possible connection under investigation," while insisting on an immediate public warning not to enter the unsafe strip. Caution and uncertainty are not opposites here: the cause may remain unproved even while preventive action against a hazard is possible. The chapter's philosophical interest concerns narrative distinctions among forms of proof, qualifying conditions and absence, but the novel's own evidence register must not be treated as a formally established instance from a canonical philosophical treatise. A question mark against Ratan's uncertain field name protects a living heir's history from false determination; uncertainty about a name is not permission to extinguish anyone's rights. The memory of Ratan's mother putting seeds, a measuring cord, medicine and a child's writing board separately in a high place becomes a miniature image of the whole narrative: preservation does not proceed by one uniform method but according to the nature of each object. A single grain of Sarita's rice, and the field debt, water and cooking time concealed behind it, offer an intertextual return to the kitchen episode of the opening chapter.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, Achievements and Limitations

The chapter begins with the preservation of a file, proceeds through present measurements at the warehouse and old memories, and ends with

an amended warning and a fixed measuring point. The past enters the present through distinct vehicles—memory, map and file. There is no independent scene of an ancient royal assembly or battlefield here. The primary narrated time runs from one day to the following dawn, yet the pre-monsoon inspection of a building, Ratan's childhood and the history of an old debt meet within it. Focalisation shifts among Aditi's professional self-criticism, Tara's discipline of measurement, Ratan's acknowledged limits of memory, the accountant's anxiety about wages and Naira's public use of language. In particular, the warehouse employee's fear and Ratan's answer demonstrate the narrator's refusal to stage the simple victory of one side.

The chapter's artistic achievement is to make "reinspection" an understated revelation of mystery. Unlike conventional detection, no criminal is captured: the chain of documents, a witness's permission, current measurements and people's wages together shape a method of inquiry. One limitation is the frequency with which Aditi, Tara, Naira and Ratan restate the same evidentiary boundaries in dialogue; dramatic conflict can resemble the typed minutes of an administrative meeting. Nevertheless, the knot of red thread, the old measuring cord, a dhoti caught in thorns, the young woman's sewn bag and a grain of rice give visible life to this abstract analysis of evidence. The established results at the close are specific: the first stable survey point is fixed, a procedure for taking samples is prepared, the difference between the original warning and its summary is recorded, and a caution about the unsafe strip is issued. The old river's true course, land rights, responsibility for the missing warning clause and the full chain of causation at the hospital remain unproved. By refusing to put Naira's private page about a "strange shadow" in the official file, the chapter closes with a separation of public and personal registers of knowledge.

Bhishma Parva / Sundara Kanda: Comparative Criticism of Chapters 65–68

The Bowl, the Strip, the Clang and the Red Thread: Narrative Trajectories of Four Evidentiary Objects

In Chapter 65, a drop from the ceiling and a bowl mark the entrance of an immediate hazard; in Chapter 66, the fundamental difference between a yellow warning strip and an order for "complete evacuation" creates a crisis of institutional duty. In Chapter 67, two distant clangs are distorted into testimony that two persons were seen; in Chapter 68, the mandatory reinspection specified in the original warning disappears from the summary. This sequence of objects is not merely poetic recurrence but a

causal narrative: the incomplete transfer of patients in Chapter 65 makes the correction of the order in Chapter 66 necessary; the unexplained clang in Chapter 66 becomes the occasion for the public distortion of witness testimony in Chapter 67; and the amended testimony of Chapter 67 underscores the need, in Chapter 68, to distinguish the original warning from the field investigation. Even with these links, it has not been established that two sounds caused the crack in the old wall; the possible relationship between water at the hospital and at the warehouse remains wholly under investigation.

The Actual Limits of a Two-Period Narrative

Chapter 66 independently enters the period before the war at Kurukshetra, though its place in the presentation returns to the beginning of the conflict after the fall of Bhishma has already been narrated. The poetic function of this displacement is to make a reader who knows the result listen afresh to the questions preceding a decision. Chapters 65, 67 and 68 contain no independent mythological scenes of this kind. Their past is reconstructed from the hospital's repair vouchers, auditory testimony, debt papers, local maps and memory. It would therefore be wrong to assign all four chapters one mechanically identical category of "two-period narration." The wider construction of Sundara Kanda is still unfolding; it would also be mistaken to take these four chapters for a definitive account of the entire kanda.

The Ethics of Evidence, Labour and the Meaning of Narration

The problem of proof is connected to safe medical transfer, patients without representatives being given a voice, payment for training, the travel time of witnesses, intellectual credit for a local measuring cord, and the present burden of older debts. The narrative's real achievement is to make "knowing correctly" not a marvel of individual intelligence but the result of many forms of labour and social collaboration. In the language of narrative analysis, the evidentiary object, the proposition at issue, reason, limiting condition, inference and non-availability may all be examined; yet the novel's events do not automatically establish a universally accepted proposition in classical theory. In Indian poetics, experiences of karuna are distributed among Sheetal, the elderly patient, Fakira and Lata; energetic courage, or purposeful endurance, appears in Devi's training decision and Aditi's public self-correction. From the perspective of Videha Parallel History, the fine-grained records of workers, nurses, artisans, elders and local women emerge against the abridged accounts produced by officials.

An Impartial Critical Counterpoint and the Questions Still Open

A particular strength is the preservation of three distinct decisions: identifying an event, taking precautions against danger, and proving a crime. Characters do not merely supply erroneous information and move on; they revise earlier statements when new information arrives. At the level of reading, however, these four chapters repeat “not yet established,” “separate register” and “reinvestigate” quite frequently. This may be an artistic imitation of the slowness of real inquiries, but the similar analytical speech given to many characters, and the continual postponement of dramatic culmination, are potential weaknesses. The ancient dialogue in Chapter 66 briefly changes the pacing, yet it too is presented in unusually explicit terms drawn from modern ethical consciousness. Future chapters leave open which adverse evidence the inquiry begun in the files will actually admit, whether witnesses receive compensation for their labour, and how the causal sequence linking the building and its drainage will be clarified. For now the warranted conclusions are limited: one patient was transferred according to plan; the phased evacuation order was amended; the false claim that Fakira was an eyewitness was withdrawn; and the difference between the original warning and its summary was recorded. The final structural defect, any possible offender, land rights and Mithun’s whereabouts have not been determined.

Chapter 69 — The Meaning of Absence

The Plurality of Empty Boxes: An Event’s Beginning and the Problem of Valid Knowledge

The chapter opens with a contrast between the active labour of moving sacks in the warehouse at Purnadhar and an empty signature box in the office receipt register. The date, number and seal on Aditi’s warning letter are present; the signature of the person who carried out reinspection is absent. At first glance, the reader might think that straightforward proof of an ineffective bureaucracy has been discovered. Yet Aditi prevents two immediate conclusions from “there is no signature”: neither “there was no inspection” nor “an inspection took place and someone deliberately concealed the name” follows. This restraint supplies the chapter’s narrative movement. An unresolved gap stops the story in its tracks, but must be addressed through new documents, access to relevant people and examination of the site register, not by conjecture. An empty box is itself a visible object; its cause is not visible. The narrator repeatedly uses this divergence because characters want an early decision while the narrative asks what that desire would cost.

At least three distinct absences become active: the missing signature in the warning's reinspection register; Suraj Gangota's absence from the current list of beneficiaries; and the failure of the debt demand to account for reduced harvests caused by erosion. They can be considered part of a common problem only if their separate administrative sources remain intact. Suraj's old account, the pledged seed-and-irrigation loan, the destroyed or diminished field and the new relief entry are related, not identical. The assistant's argument—if the name is not on the list, how can there be a right to apply?—turns the absence of a person from a record into the supposed nonexistence of the person's claim. Naira asks about the year in which the list was prepared, the spelling of the name and the relationship between the old account and the current list. Resistance here does not mean an order requiring payment: it means refusing to deny the right to have an application heard before the inquiry begins. The limited success is truer to evidence than an unwarranted triumph would be.

Tara shows the old site lines and Aditi's present blue marks. No one is entitled to fill the intervening space according to personal preference. In this landscape of water and land, the name "Dhemura" or the older identity of a strip at Purnadhar does not automatically establish present property rights. The novel's socio-ecological perspective lays claim not merely to symbolic affection for a river, but to procedures of measurement and the lives of landholders. Erosion of Suraj's field has disappeared from the accounting of debt, yet the physical loss of soil has not disappeared. The first important turn of the chapter is that an absence in documents is not an absence on the earth; equally, the suffering of the earth does not automatically constitute a legal order to revise a loan.

Udayana's Philosophical Debate: The Illegitimate Leap from Non-Apprehension to Nonexistence

In the ninth section the narrative opens from the modern office into a grove of ancient Mithila. In the debate between Udayana and his opponent, the non-apprehension of God by direct perception, the grounds of inference, and the proper status of knowledge of absence are examined separately. The opponent brings an empty oil vessel as an example of negation. Udayana accepts the vessel's present emptiness, but refuses to conclude from it either that oil is absent throughout the city or that the vessel never contained oil in the past. The philosophical value of the discussion does not lie in the simplified slogan "not seen means not existing"; rather, it lies in defining the object, its expected availability, and the appropriate conditions for perception. Udayana's answer does not encompass the entire classical history of the competing traditions of inference and non-apprehension. This is a creative philosophical

disputation, not a verified verbatim quotation from the Nyayakusumanjali.

In the fourteenth section, the modern narrative expressly states that the philosophical debate was not evidence for Suraj's debt slip. This deliberate caution prevents the writer from substituting an ancient argument for a modern judicial decision. The classical question provides a method of thinking: when an object that should be available under proper conditions is not found, some limited knowledge of absence may be possible; failure to see an object in an inappropriate domain cannot establish nonexistence. Tested against this distinction, the office assistant's reasoning, the missing page of the inspection register and Faguni's unrecorded labour all become available for re-examination. The language of narrative epistemology is useful, but the novel does not make its characters recite a complete five-member syllogism. The issue is the legitimate scope of proof.

The difference between voices in the philosophical debate and modern dialogue also deserves attention. Ancient scholars dispute grounds and counter-grounds; Kanaklata, Suraj and Faguni discuss the categories of debt, income, penalty and work. A critic who reduces both levels to "all the characters speak the same language" because of their shared logical structure would miss their distinct social purposes. Even so, the unusually well-ordered tone of the dialogue does prompt the reader to ask why actual uncertainty in labouring families so often becomes a sequence of such procedural sentences. The convenience of philosophical concepts can sometimes suppress a character's linguistic individuality. That should be counted among the chapter's artistic limitations.

Three Lines of Debt, Faguni's Labour and the Time of a Life

Kanaklata separates the principal, interest previously added, and penalties for delay after the erosion. Debt is not one undifferentiated moral offence: its components have different origins, repayment histories and regulatory dates. Suraj does not make an unsubstantiated demand for total cancellation. He asks first that amounts already paid not reappear as outstanding, and that instalments following crop destruction be evaluated against actual labour and possible income. The cooperative's written reply states that a proposal to suspend new penalties for delay is before the committee; it is not an actual waiver or a comprehensive order halting recovery. Initial consideration of restructuring has been accepted, while measurements of erosion and old payment receipts remain subject to examination. Here the distinction among proposal, consideration, approval and implementation determines the real event-value of the plot.

Suraj's and Harihar's conversation beneath a peepal tree opposes administrative time to generational time. The son contemplates leaving

for Delhi; the father refuses to abandon the land-and-debt hearing. Migration to the city is not represented as cowardice, nor is the field treated as an eternal identity. Harihar retains the right to decide for himself. The gift of an empty red-earth box in the thirty-first section is a symbol of memory or the future, not evidence that the land has been restored. Harihar decides not to leave for the city yet, but first to attend the hearing with his mother and father. His permanent course of life remains undecided. This open option is an important creative achievement in the development of the character.

Faguni first enters through the household meal and then opens a small notebook recording her time spent transplanting rice, weeding and carrying food to the embankment. Lack of formal title to the land does not negate the existence of labour. Only Suraj's name appears in the debt ledger, whereas Faguni's work notebook records countless days. This comparison provides concrete material for a Videha Parallel History perspective. Kanaklata, however, does not treat Faguni's notebook as an automatic document of debt release; she allows it to accompany the account of the affected family's income and losses. Making a woman's work visible is a social achievement, not proof that compensation has been granted. The distance between the farmer's official record and the woman's informal reckoning gives living meaning, alongside classical thought, to labour left "outside" history.

From the Missing Page to Printed News: An Enlargement of Risk, Not Closure

A number corresponding to the inspection date is found in the visitors' register, but the following page containing the name and purpose is unavailable. Even when a box is later opened, the page is not found. There is an indication that it was handed to the old repairs division, not proof that it was destroyed. Aditi's insistence—do not assume that something was destroyed merely because it was not found in a box—is an effective dramatisation of the negative limits of evidence. The distinction has social importance: negligent handling by an employee and a possible deliberate suppression of a document warrant significantly different public allegations. Beginning a numbered search for the missing material is real work, not a final answer.

In the chapter's final four sections, the ordinary office's "empty box" becomes a threat to a family's identity. Mahesh asks for a draft news report to be recalled because its address and family relationships could identify a witness despite the omission of a full name. Naira asks for confirmation that the revised version was actually published; an oral assurance is insufficient. During the night Mahesh receives a message that printing has

stopped and correction is no longer possible. At this point, documentary absence and the excessive presence of publicly revealing clues become opposite ends of the narrative curve. An empty signature box was the first form of risk; the irreversible distribution of printed paper is now the second. Mahesh writes that confidential contact with the family is essential, but awareness of the risk has not averted it. The final scene is composed of a desk lamp, two sheets of paper and an unanswered telephone, which will become the darkness of a home and an attack in the next chapter.

Critically considered, Chapter 69 succeeds by preventing "absence" from becoming a single-line philosophical sermon: an empty signature box, an absent name, a lost strip of farmland, unrecorded women's labour and an incomplete request for correction follow different causal paths. A limitation is the exceptionally rule-governed structure of some office conversations and the relative ease with which Kanaklata's hearing appears to conclude. Nevertheless, the unfinished debt decision and the immediacy of danger arising from the printed report propel the reader forward while keeping contrary evidence in view.

Chapter 70 — Mahesh's Night

Anonymous Publication, Recognisable Identity: The Indirect Language of Publicity and Risk

A wet newspaper at Mahesh's door, school shoes dried by his daughter and news picked up by his wife bring the ordinary labour of home together with the possibility of public violence. The report does not print Mahesh's name, but clues about his earlier work at the warehouse, the place beyond the railway line and his family's route may identify him. The paper's authority here consists not in complete factual accuracy but in spreading an identity by stimulating the reader's conjectures. The novel rejects the premise that removing a full name is sufficient to protect confidentiality. Several people near the market have asked the daughter about her father, but whether they were prompted by the newspaper or by other information has not been established. Her account must be heard; it would nevertheless be wrong to convert signs of fear into conclusive proof of how the witness was identified.

The editor promises to change the online version, but copies already printed and distributed will not return. Digital correction and physical dissemination move according to different times. Naira keeps four sources distinct: her earlier civic post as originally published, the moment of its deletion, Mahesh's restricted permission and the newly printed report. She moves towards accepting responsibility for her initial publication; yet the

original text does not establish that everyone connected with the news shares responsibility for the same offence. In the editorial room, a revised headline such as "Identity Unclear" might invite a hunt for the person's identity instead of protecting it. Through this fine linguistic criticism the narrative reveals an awareness of the craft of reporting: announcing that information is absent may itself provoke an intensified search.

Domestic Time and the Separate Stages of Security Procedures

Mahesh's wife presents the legal-aid office with a list of what her daughter needs: books, medicine, a route to work, water and temporary accommodation. This does not diminish her husband's importance as a witness; it relocates the centre of the family's reality from "the usefulness of testimony" to "the time necessary for living." The school has received a restricted instruction not to send the child with anyone else without a parent's written permission. This is a modest but completed safety measure. Confidential accommodation for the wife and daughter has not been approved, however, nor has a written order been issued for a personal guard at night. A receipt number for an application, a proposal to increase patrols and an actual deployment of protection are three distinct administrative stages. The narrative keeps the reader's attention on their sequence because the meaning of these omissions will become acute when the attack follows.

Mahesh's wife sends Naira a clear written request to suppress clues that could reveal the family's identity. Naira does not try to secure her "consent" again by telephone; she gives Kabir information about the procedure alone. The family's autonomy is not made a theatrical instrument for the heroine's remorse. Decisions about the lives of the husband, wife and daughter belong to them. The public dignity of a witness extends into his private home, down to a vessel of drinking water and a school bottle. By the end of the day Mahesh himself recognises that right. The central question of feminist narratology here is not whether the wife is courageous, but whether she decides and acts within the story, or merely assists an injured man. The scenes available reject the latter possibility.

Signatures for Materials, Pressure on a Witness and an Uncertain Motive for Crime

Raghav Singh's nephew acknowledges that he personally recorded the date when materials arrived; he does not recognise as his own the signature attributed to him on a different page. He refuses to turn delivery of materials, their actual installation and the building's safety into a single answer. Raghav does not want his nephew to lie merely to preserve a contract. At the legal-aid office, the young man insists on ownership of his

own statement: he will speak in his uncle's presence, but give his own answers. The scene expresses the conflict between a young person's authority over his testimony and familial obligations. A telephone threat warns him that further consignments will cease if he speaks; a subsequent written notice suspends the next supply order. Yet a criminal conspiracy has not been established as the actual motive behind the suspension. The relationship is a matter for inquiry, not a conclusion.

Aditi separates the receipt of four items from Meena's repair voucher and Lalit's refusal to certify a load. The artisan, engineer, contractor and family witness have different domains of knowledge. Avoiding a one-dimensional accusation is important, though repeated distinctions among types of proof now risk slowing the pace. Readers can feel the moral pressure on the nephew without being told repeatedly that "one kind of evidence is not another." In some places that refrain sounds like an authorial lecture. Despite this artistic limitation, the young man's fear of losing contracts and Raghav's uneasy cooperation save the voices of the characters from becoming entirely documentary explanation.

Mahesh receives a threat from an anonymous number telling him to think of his home. The sender's actual identity is unknown. The demand for protection is not a prediction of a particular murder; given a direct threat and the spread of identifying clues, it is a reasonable precaution. The narrative permits the reader to suspect a conspiracy but, by withholding the offender's name from an omniscient narrator, practises fidelity to evidence as well as creating suspense. A critic who writes either "the person who suspended the contract was the criminal" or "the newspaper printed the family's name" would go beyond the original prose.

The Night Attack: Scene Duration, Restricted Perception and the Cost of Duty

In the twenty-first section, the milk vessel, school bottle and parcel of medicines inside Mahesh's home establish the rhythm of everyday life. A knock in the night shatters this familiar rhythm. Mahesh does not open the door. From outside a voice calls about "the accounts of the old warehouse." The words are a professed pretext, not direct proof of the attackers' real purpose. A powerful kick splits the wood; a heavy object breaks the glass; and a shard cuts Mahesh's left arm. No eyewitness can fully identify how many attackers there were, whose faces they saw, or who owned the motorcycle. The writer stretches the running of neighbours, the wife's effort to move the daughter to safety, the bandaging of the wound and a neighbour's discreet call for help into a sustained scene. In place of a documentary summary, we encounter an intensified sequence of bodies, sounds and physical reactions.

Salma's assistance at the hospital and the physician's examination fix an important chronological limit. Mahesh is alive in this chapter; the cut from the glass is being assessed and treated, and no immediate life-threatening condition has been recorded. After the attack, Mahesh says himself that he cannot identify his assailants. His wife reiterates the urgency of the safety list. Kabir starts requesting written copies and discreetly exploring possible shelter, but neither an order for regular protection nor full agreement about refuge has been obtained. By the time the night has passed, only a request for an immediate patrol has been accepted; the security crisis remains. The story does not yet fully satisfy the reader's emotional hope that reaching hospital means the protagonist is safe.

The River Drawing and the Family's Hopes Before the Trauma

For the first time in this chapter, the daughter's drawing of a river becomes a major imaginative object distinct from the emergency. The child understands the river as both a path and a bridge. Her wish for a safe route to school is an incomplete but precise expression of childhood knowledge. The drawing will travel to the hospital, become folded on the veranda and turn into an object of remembrance in the following chapter. Here the river is not a measured watercourse on a map; from the child's perspective, it is the right to travel between fear and the future. Seeing the drawing in Mahesh's hand is not a decorative device for producing tears in a hospital scene, because the drawing belongs to the girl. Mahesh's wife gives her daughter an opportunity to hear the truth; silencing the child is not the only possible way of protecting her father.

The chapter runs from the morning newspaper through the newsroom and the hours of security applications to a night attack and hospital treatment. The contracting span of a day and night intensifies tension. Each document obeys its own administrative clock, while the attackers' arrival is independent of those schedules. Focalisation rotates among Naira, Mahesh, his wife, the nephew and Kabir, but the attackers' inner thoughts remain concealed. This is a refusal of the easy omniscience that would declare the criminal motive proven. The chapter's literary achievement is the density of domestic life before the crisis. A potential limitation is its repeated, elaborate reporting of the status of government orders. At the end, however, the wife writes down not a guard's name but the time of the next visit. In a crisis life proceeds not through slogans about "complete security" but through decisions about the next hour.

Chapter 71 — Death and Documents

Yesterday's Wound and Today's Blow: The Causal Limits of the Death Event

Chapter 71 begins at dawn on the hospital veranda, with the date of Mahesh's wound dressing written on a slip in his wife's hand. Mahesh attempts to put on his kurta with one hand, and his daughter fastens the buttons. This small act of bodily assistance humanises the consequence of the first attack without confusing its glass injury with the cause of his later death. The process of medical discharge is under way, but there is no clear written arrangement for safely escorting the family out through the public exit. His wife separates three files: treatment, the attack complaint and confidential accommodation. This classification shows how hospital, police and security administration exercise different kinds of authority over the same injured body at different times. Mahesh wants to ensure that his previous witness statement reaches an authorised officer. His account remains limited to his direct observation of materials being received; he did not himself see where they were installed. Because he acknowledges this limit, even though his later death gives the accusation emotional weight, it cannot furnish complete objective proof of defective construction.

Permission for temporary accommodation comes around midday; a secured vehicle is to reach the closed rear veranda of the hospital. This is the novel's tragic irony: protective procedures have advanced on paper, but the family's safe exit has not yet been completed. To verify the signature of an injured applicant, an office employee requires Mahesh to appear in person. Kabir suggests that the officer come to his bed instead, but pressure for an immediate meeting remains. This decision must be assessed carefully. The story presents the sequence linking procedural pressure to the location of the attack, but nowhere proves that a particular employee deliberately created conditions favourable to an assault. The official's carelessness or an office's procedural rigidity can be criticised; the reader cannot manufacture a claim of direct involvement in a murder conspiracy.

In the seventh and eighth sections, narrative time suddenly becomes dense. A half-dark corridor, a wooden crate, an old bed, a washing drum, a closed office door and a narrow entrance at the rear form the physical setting in which the attack occurs. Two persons enter. One calls Mahesh's name and shoves him; a heavy iron object is seen in the hand of the other. A blow rings out and Mahesh falls. Kabir chooses to summon help, remaining with the wounded man rather than running after the attackers. At this moment a character's morality consists not in an unnecessary heroic pursuit but in activating the means of immediate treatment. Kabir sees

two figures, neither face clearly. The limits of knowledge established from the outset become most consequential here: a brutal act of killing has occurred, but the killers have not been identified.

The doctor's work, changes of bed, medication and the wife watching the hands of the clock unfold in a dense duration of scene. The earlier dressing is still on Mahesh's arm, but the medical crisis leading to death results from the second blow to his head. Towards evening the doctor gives the time at which death is recorded. The event register marks a decisive change: Mahesh, alive though injured in Chapter 70, is dead in Chapter 71. The date in the death register and the medical information about cause are necessary, but a detailed examination of the assault, post-mortem examination and criminal investigation are separate processes. It would be false to treat Mahesh's murder as an automatic consequence of the old hospital building's defects. The primary event is physical violence by assailants whose motives and organisers remain to be discovered.

The Bereaved Family's Viewpoint: Wife and Daughter at the Centre of the Story

The narrative does not turn the wife into an object placed in a scene of grief. She decides how to manage essential telephone calls, a safe place for her daughter and the available information about treatment. The daughter is not falsely reassured that her father will survive; her mother tells her plainly that he will not return. Only a few hours earlier the child had fastened his kurta buttons. The brief recollection of that gesture is the sharpest literary source of sorrow. In contrast with so many earlier documentary details, this intimacy of bodily touch could have remained simple and unexplained. The narrator lets the child cry without ordering her to be silent. From the perspective of rasa theory the possibility of karuna rasa is present, but the reader's feeling arises from the situation of the scene, not merely from declaring it "pathetic" or "sorrowful."

Naira's guilt after Mahesh's death forms a second centre of the narrative's ethics. She admits the error of putting hints about the warehouse, professional designation and family route together in her earlier civic report. The newspaper editor suggests collective self-exoneration in the name of the public good. Naira decides instead to distinguish criminal wrongdoing from a mistake in publication. That distinction is indispensable: responsibility for committing the killing lies with the perpetrators; editorial responsibility for publishing inappropriate clues to an identity is separate. The story does not establish a single, direct criminal chain of causation between Naira's lapse and the murder. She owns her error without asserting that an unidentified person commanded the

killing. The precise limits of public apology alert the reader that accepting ethical responsibility is not the same as being convicted of a crime.

There is a possible artistic limitation in this self-examination. Naira's analysis is exceptionally orderly, as if three categories of allegation had already been prepared for the reader. Some may expect her language to fracture in grief, or to show more disorganised traces of pride and self-protection. The novel does not completely empty her feelings of form: opening the published edition, deciding not to visit the house, and pausing before writing an apology indicate an emotional response. Still, Naira's sentences retain the disciplined language of a classical theory of proof. This question does not diminish her achievement; it examines the balance between the work's philosophical intentions and its immediate emotional force.

Three Sites of Evidence and the Meaning of Professional Labour for the Dead

Kabir confirms that he saw two figures at the site, but deletes his recollection that their clothes were red. An officer makes a list for checking the duty register, the rear door and the camera. Whether the camera was operating is unknown. The damaged door of the house from the first attack, the hospital corridor where the second occurred, and the old warehouse's materials register are three independent sites of evidence. This specificity of place is not merely "narrative space" in narratological terminology: it restrains the construction of criminal causation. Proximity in time or a common reference to the warehouse does not establish the same offender. Raghav seeks a time for his nephew's statement through a lawyer rather than silencing him by force. The nephew is afraid, but failing to give a statement does not itself make him guilty.

The arrival of Shashibhushan Mahapatra outside the mortuary is particularly important. He carries bamboo, white cloth, thread and a ledger of wages. He is not the official writer of the death certificate; he is a professional supplying necessary materials and labour in the midst of mourning. His two pages of costs separate materials from his own remuneration. The scene permits resistance to the tendency to call post-mortem care a "meritorious deed" and thereby turn its necessary work into invisible, unpaid labour. Shashibhushan keeps accurate accounts of advances and balances due and imposes no unnecessary rites. Here Videha Parallel History requires that the worker's name and wages not be concealed behind an epic hero's grief. The dignity of the deceased and the rights of the living worker are not opposites. Still, the writer specifies the new character's occupational details so fully in the midst of bereavement that some readers may experience a momentary interruption of grief. This

vocational elaboration fulfils the novel's declared social breadth, but also exacts a cost from its affective rhythm.

The wife decides which documents to share and with whom. The original of Mahesh's statement remains under an authorised seal, and an application seeks removal of private location details from public copies. A written receipt for the murder investigation has been issued, but the attackers' identities, possible contractual connections and an order assigning regular security personnel remain unresolved. A neighbour receives a restricted key to collect clothes and books from the old house. The woman's self-determination is unmistakable in these boundaries: between her dead husband and the state, the wife becomes a legal voice in her own right. She defers answering whether they will return to the house. This hesitation is not weakness but a defence against being forced into a residential decision.

The Unstamped Memory of the Drawing: Truth Outside the Archive

At the end of the chapter the daughter's river drawing, with a brief private note by Mahesh on its reverse, remains without any official seal. Its literary value is extraordinary. A murder investigation file may preserve the time of Mahesh's death, the site and an estimate of the blow; it cannot give the daughter the full meaning of the life she shared with her father. The drawing is neither medical evidence nor direct proof of an allegation, yet its reality is established in the domain of personal memory and relationship. This is not an illegitimate extension of narrative epistemology but a critical grasp of the separate domains to which kinds of evidence belong. Personal memory does not stand above criminal justice, but legal documents are not heirs to the whole meaning of an individual life.

The chapter's fundamental success is its refusal to turn grief into a cheap device of emotional atonement. Naira admits a mistake, but the dead Mahesh does not return to life; a request for protection may be accepted without adequate arrangements being made everywhere; and Shashibhushan's outstanding bill is not paid by proclaiming moral virtue. In comparison, the living Sarita was recorded as dead in the opening chapter, whereas here the death of the actually deceased Mahesh is entered medically. This shadow dialogue matters to the work as a whole, but it would be wrong to treat the two as identical events or the same institutional error. Mahesh's death is not merely an incorrect name on an official sheet: it is the irreversible loss of a living body. In this sense the long ethical preparation of Bhishma Parva acquires an unbearable and concrete tragedy.

Chapter 72 — Sanjaya's Distance

Two Figures and One Blow: The Precise Wording of Testimony

Three pages lie on the table at the start of Chapter 72: the preliminary checklist for investigating Mahesh's death, a map of the site and Kabir's statement. The written account implies that Kabir "saw two attackers deliver blows." That was not his direct experience. He saw two figures, the moment of one blow and Mahesh falling. Whether the second person struck him is unknown. The employee's abridgment has transformed an unknown act into a supposedly established event. Correcting that sentence is not a minor editorial change; it corrects the boundaries of a possible allegation. The earlier page is not torn out but attached to the amendment. This two-document arrangement preserves the historical chain of evidence. The essential textual principle for a critic is that fewer words do not necessarily produce greater truth, and even an orderly summary may generate a claim different from the witness's original account.

Kabir's objection forms a narrative sequence with the administrative mistake in Chapter 67, where Fakira's "heard" had been turned into "seen." Fakira heard a sound, but the paper made him a witness who saw two people. Kabir saw two figures, but the record makes him a witness who saw both deliver blows. The recurrence is more than thematic repetition: it tests differing sensory experiences of witnesses and differing levels of a criminal act. Yet the story once again teaches the need to separate four explicit categories—receipt, direct perception, inference and confidential information. Both its artistic effect and the repetition of its method should be recorded.

Sanjaya's Divine Sight and Limited Knowledge: Testing the Two-Period Narrative

In the fifth section, the modern investigation opens into the audience chamber of Hastinapura in the distant past. Dhritarashtra asks after Bhishma; Sanjaya says that Bhishma lies on a bed of arrows but is still alive. Through Vyasa's blessing Sanjaya can perceive scenes of a distant battle. This is an epic and imaginary system of knowledge, not the ordinary direct perception of a witness in contemporary law. The novel does not deny its miraculous nature, but refuses to permit Sanjaya—even with divinely granted vision—to attribute to himself every unknown motive of the mind or the complete decisive meaning of what lies ahead. Sanjaya himself distinguishes event from intention. Thus the affinity between exceptional ancient sight and limited modern testimony resides solely in ethical self-restraint, not in the nature of sensory proof.

Dhritarashtra's narrative position is different. He cannot see the scene; he hears Sanjaya and then constructs an image in his mind. The king asks whose conch sounded under whose command and for what fear or purpose particular soldiers fight. Sanjaya refuses to regard every soldier as a willing representative of Duryodhana's wishes: labour, livelihood, fear and royal obligation are distinct reasons for service in the army. At this moment the account of war ceases to be merely a summary of a dynasty's victory or defeat and becomes a history of anonymous bodies carrying the war's burden. This is important for Videha Parallel History. But a critic must not assert that the novel supplies the real names, genealogies and complete independent life stories of those nameless soldiers. On the contrary, Sanjaya declines to invent biographies for people who have not been identified. This ethical restraint in representation also indicates the limit of the narrative's epic breadth.

The ancient scene gathers the first day of war, the dialogue of Arjuna and Krishna, and Bhishma's fall on the tenth day into Sanjaya's account. Events spanning many days are condensed into the time of speaking in a single audience chamber. Chapter 66 had presented Arjuna's pre-battle dialogue at length; here it is retold by Sanjaya. The distinction between narrative levels matters: previously the reader watched an ancient scene as it "happened"; now Sanjaya narrates that event to Dhritarashtra. Bhishma's fall and his death remain separate here as well. Sanjaya does not reduce Shikhandi's active presence on the chariot to a passive shield, and he states Arjuna's role in delivering the arrows. Dhritarashtra's grief does not automatically erase responsibility for royal decisions.

The imagined picture formed within Dhritarashtra and the distant vision available to Sanjaya are different. The king finally tells Sanjaya to say so even when he does not know something. This changes the nature of a royal hearing: instead of demanding total certainty, the listener permits uncertainty to be borne. Sanjaya's speech becomes a responsible narrative act rather than an unbroken omniscience. Nevertheless, characters in the ancient temporal strand frequently speak in the language of modern source ethics. This linguistic contemporisation makes the work's intellectual connections clear but risks obscuring stylistic and traditional differences in the original Mahabharata narrative. The critical limit of this section must be marked: the reconstructed Sanjaya is not the verbatim Sanjaya of the historical Sanskrit text.

Four Times and Sources of Knowledge in the Modern Investigation

Returning to modern Videhapur, Naira keeps separate Mahesh's receipt for submitting his statement, Kabir's amended testimony and the hospital time register. A receipt proves that a statement was submitted, not that every allegation within it has been verified. When entry and exit pages are

kept in reverse order, the order of the papers changes, not the recorded times themselves. Without verification, a five-minute difference between two clocks cannot be turned into an unexplained interval in the crime. Narrative time can be divided here into four levels: the time when the event occurred, the time the record was made, the time a copy was prepared, and the time of its presentation in the text. The narrative places particular emphasis on correcting the clocks used in the inquiry. The credibility of testimony consequently depends not only on memory but on the temporal organisation of external records.

On the site map an officer draws an arrow towards the warehouse to indicate a possible direction of flight; Kabir refuses to include it as part of his direct testimony. The arrow is not erased but marked separately as an "investigative inference." This scene makes revision of language into revision of visual arrangement: a line of the same colour cannot establish two different kinds of valid knowledge. The nephew acknowledges signing for delivery of materials, not for testing the building's safe use. Preparations are made for his authorised statement, on condition that he first sees the original materials voucher. These events create new paths for verifying facts, not a full exposure of a murder conspiracy.

Naira's editor proposes a headline along the lines of "An Eyewitness Reveals the Face." She refuses, since no face has been identified. The later report publishes the killing, the continuing inquiry and the existence of Kabir's amended testimony, without inventing an offender's name or the source of orders. The apology in Chapter 71 is becoming a practical editorial correction here. An ethical transformation in a writer is not adequately tested by speeches of regret alone; it must be tested in the discipline of the next sentence and headline. There is thus concrete textual evidence that Naira's character development produces a different decision after her admission of fault.

The Search for Mithun, the Letter from Simatirtha and the Child's Private Memory

Lata holds a copy bearing the name "Mithua," an incomplete boat fare and an elder's reported account. The return of this other plotline, away from grief over Mahesh's murder investigation, matters. The original novel does not allow the duration of other characters' rights to end merely because one person's story reaches a devastating conclusion. Lata does not take a similarity in red thread as conclusive proof of Mithun's identity; she writes down questions about who possesses the original slip and who saw the date of travel. Motherhood here is not a symbol of blind conjecture but an active, careful process of knowing through inquiry. The child has not

yet been found; only a possible direction for the search awaits confirmation.

The episode involving Tara, Padma and the water committee's letter of introduction serves as a transitional thread from Bhishma Parva to Drona Parva. It raises the need not to print the names of workers on a border journey without consent, to preserve the source-language and translated copies separately, and to specify the boat fare and wages for language assistance. After the disaster of unsafe publication involving Mahesh, concern for consent is stronger at the beginning of another journey. This demonstrates a causal ethical development; it does not establish that the journey has been completed or a border agreement concluded. The story turns from one decisive death towards other forms of social life still pending.

In the new residence Mahesh's daughter places her river drawing between the pages of a book. When her mother asks, she asserts ownership of it herself. The child's right to grieve for her father does not give others permission to turn her loss into material for a public statement every time they wish. If the dignity of Sanjaya's narration lies in "when I do not know, I shall say that I do not know," the child's situation yields a further ethical principle: "What belongs to someone's private memory must not be spoken at another person's wish." These principles are different—one limits claims to knowledge, the other limits what consent permits—but the novel brings them into conversation. Compassion is expressed in the child's small private decision, not by using her grief as a decorative ending to a vast epic.

Bhishma Parva / Sundara Kanda: Comprehensive Critical Assessment of Chapters 61–72

From a Vow to a Murder Investigation: The Event Sequence of Twelve Chapters

The first four chapters of Bhishma Parva take up the conditions set by Shantanu and Ganga, Devavrata's vow, Amba's search for justice and Shikhandi's self-determination. Chapters 65–68 then introduce the hospital's old wing, the ethical dialogue of Arjuna and Krishna before the war, Fakira's restricted auditory testimony, and the divergence between the original warning letter and its summary in Aditi's records. In the final four chapters, a gap in the register, the indirect publication of clues to Mahesh's confidential identity, the assault on his home, his murder at the hospital, revision of Kabir's eyewitness testimony, and Sanjaya's report in the royal court produce an appalling but multi-stranded result. At least

three decisive states change: unsafe publication involving Mahesh is followed by an actual threat to his family; Mahesh changes from an injured living man into a dead man; and the wording of testimony and publication is revised after his death. Many other actions remain partial: the missing page of the inspection register is not found; the killers are not identified; regular protection has not been approved; Mithun's location is unknown; and the journey to Simatirtha remains ahead. Before calling these incompletions defects in the story, one should examine their causal work.

The Achievements and Limits of Classical Intertextuality

Bhishma's vow, Amba's dissent, Shikhandi's decision, Arjuna's hesitation before battle and Sanjaya's narration are not imposed on modern people as a single set of exemplary characters. The firmness of Bhishma's word and the firmness of Mahesh's testimony belong to different historical and ethical circumstances; Amba's refusal is not the literal source of the wife's and daughter's right to consent. Shikhandi's active role on the battlefield is restored through Sanjaya's account in Chapter 72. Udayana's arguments concerning non-apprehension in Chapter 69 and Sanjaya's limits of knowledge in Chapter 72 furnish a shared critical thread between philosophy and narration. Yet the classical inferential argument of the Nyayakusumanjali is not a method of modern police investigation. The story's strength lies in its alertness to these boundaries. A possible weakness is the exceptionally modern, accountability-centred speech of the ancient characters, which sometimes diminishes the linguistic differences between temporal strands.

The Ramayana designation "Sundara Kanda" applies structurally to these twelve chapters of Bhishma Parva, but no independent scene of Hanuman in Lanka functions as a principal narrative foundation in this final section. It would therefore be groundless to attach a direct Sundara Kanda event-equivalent to Chapters 69–72. Here the kanda's structural position proposes a broader reading of obtaining distant testimony, crossing risk and accepting responsibility for a message; it does not establish a scene-by-scene correspondence for every chapter. Resisting that temptation reduces the error of treating a resemblance between headings as sufficient intertextual analysis.

Focalisation, Narrative Time and the Structure of Evidence

The parva's temporal arrangement is unusually recursive: from the present-day hospital to the Mahabharata past, then back to the modern office, warehouse, home and murder investigation. Chapter 66 returns to the beginning of the war; Chapter 72 has Sanjaya narrate the same war again, creating different narrative levels for one group of events. In the

contemporary strand, the husband, wife, daughter, Naira, Aditi, Kabir, Fakira and the nephew each possess localised knowledge. No character's account supplies certainty about the investigation as a whole. A third-person narrator connects scenes and gives the reader more sequential information than any one character possesses, but does not magically reveal the unknown criminal's motives and identity. In that sense, the distribution of knowledge becomes an ethical form of justification.

One methodological advantage of the design informed by narratology is that it exposes illegitimate leaps: from "receipt signature" to "completed inspection"; from "two figures" to "two blows"; from "a sound heard" to "an event seen"; and from "an identity revealed through publication" to "a definite order issued by the killer." At times, however, the philosophical test becomes the narrator's favourite pedagogical posture. Separate columns for four documents, separate columns for times, and columns for what was accepted or rejected appear repeatedly. This recurrence should not automatically be celebrated as "polyphony"; it can arrest the story's movement. Nevertheless, the moment of actual violence and the child's drawing in the wake of grief return this abstract language to a world of embodied lives.

Videha Parallel History, Labour and the Politics of Grief

The history of this parva is not confined to royal heroes and administrative officers. Salma's cleaning work, Gomati's handling of sacks, Lalit's concern for load safety, Faguni's reckoning of transplanting labour, Shashibhushan's remuneration for care after death, a neighbour's confidential assistance, the wife's decisions about residence, and the daughter's ownership of a remembered picture all constitute active lives of characters ordinarily left outside the principal story of politics or historiography. The novel writes the names and value of this labour into its public narrative world. Merely recording many occupations, however, is not sufficient to establish depth of character. Readers will want to know how decisions, injuries and the consequences of lasting relationships develop in later chapters. The possible weakness of turning characters into a catalogue must be tested again in the parvas that follow.

Bhishma Parva does not conclude in triumph. Mahesh's murder is the irreversible death of a character; his wife and daughter require arrangements for living, protection and self-determination. Naira's public admission is an ethical beginning to correcting a failure of verification, not full justice for the murder. Kabir's amended testimony corrects the accusation without identifying the offender. Sanjaya's restraint in saying "I do not know everything" and the daughter's choice to keep her drawing in her own book preserve two different boundaries of the human right to narrate. The central question for the forthcoming Drona Parva will be

this: when life cannot be restored, how much genuine rebuilding of social existence is possible through evidence, justice, witness protection and memory? This criticism will not predetermine the answer, but examine it against the events of the original chapters as they unfold.

Drona Parva / Sundara Kanda

Chapter 73 — The Landing at Simatirtha

The Boat's Planking: Labour and Safety Before the Journey

The chapter begins not with the travelling party but with Madhu Kewat's working hands. Examining the hairline cracks in the damp boat planking at dawn, drawing out an iron spike, and deciding where the load must be shifted are not incidental technical details outside the story. Through these actions, the narrative establishes that the principal agents of the journey to Simatirtha are not only Tara, Padma and Lata, carrying papers, but also the boatman who understands the river's dangers. Madhu enters the boat fare, the weight of goods, the hours spent unloading and any charge for waiting under separate headings in his ledger. The absence of a signature on a slip presented by an employee asking for free passage in the name of public welfare cannot itself turn that slip into an official public-interest order. The employee withdraws the incomplete proposal: Madhu's labour does not become an unpriced public resource.

The opening sequence of events is precise: a crack is discovered in the boat; the load must be inspected; the additional iron tools are taken off; they are left with a responsible person against a receipt; and the travellers disembark safely at the first halt. Tara carries a map and the failed agreement, but she is not an expert in calculating a boat's load; Madhu possesses technical authority in this matter. Respect for that boundary provides the ethical basis of a collective decision. The journey does not begin immediately: the delay for safety is an event in its own right. A critic who describes this as 'full government approval for a safe boat service' would destroy the original scene's subtlety. The boat sailed, an advance fare was paid, and the possible additional waiting charge remained open: those are the verifiable results.

Shanti Bote's dispute over the carriage charge for two sacks opens this preliminary question of justice from another angle. The register on the landing office's table records the receipt of one sack although she delivered two. Madhu mentions Shanti's claim but does not enter the payment as completed in his own ledger. The red mark left across a palm by the boat's wet rope is a natural object of testimony, yet it cannot substitute for official proof of the outstanding sum. From the perspective of Videha Parallel History, such fine-grained records of daily wages disclose the value of lives excluded from grand narratives of the state. Crucially, Shanti exists independently of the travelling party: her earnings on the following day, her family's consignment and her own slip retain their distinct causal lives within the plot.

Travel, Linguistic Mediation, and Lata's Right to Decide

Tara sets out with three bags, Padma with questions about the original language, and Lata with her personal notebook. Lata's question is who keeps the original register bearing the name 'Mithua'; it is not an announcement that Mithun has been found. Padma explains that similarity between names does not establish the identity of persons, while Lata protects her motherhood from the repeated charge of irrational haste. The development of the characters in this exchange goes beyond a movement from hope towards doubt: the roles within their collaboration are redefined. Padma has authority to explain the meaning of words; Lata has authority to decide whose answer she will accept. This distinction recurs later in the relationship between the interpreter and a local woman at the water committee meeting.

At the landing on the far bank, signs reading 'Gandak' and 'Gandaki', and elsewhere an old fare-route marked 'Gohi', do not become a thrilling new geographical discovery. Shanti warns that an office's understanding, the writing on an old slip, and the actual position of a river channel are different sources. Padma records both names but announces neither that there are two distinct rivers nor that they are definitely one. Place here is not merely a scenic background: an incorrect name may generate disputes over wages, fares, addresses and the right of entry. It is consequently more appropriate to examine the source-history of river names than to reduce river geography to a symbolic 'motherland'.

In the Simatirtha market, Kumudi limits her services to two meetings and treats the showing of a route, listening to the parties, and producing a written translation as separate kinds of labour. At first Tara considers the charge excessive, but Kumudi's question changes the frame of her judgement. Lata insists that a question must not be shortened when it is translated; Kumudi agrees to register disagreements over the original wording in a blank space. Multilingualism here is not ornamentation but a struggle over the distribution of knowledge. Uttering a sentence in two languages is not mere repetition: it is work that can prevent future material harm caused by misconstruction. Even so, Kumudi's interpretation is not itself representation; a local woman chooses her own language. The argument gains force from its distinction between ownership of a voice and ownership of the medium by which that voice is carried.

Contracts of Craftsmanship: The Concrete Outcomes of a Small Agreement

Sonmati Turi's bamboo frames, Niru Kumal's vessels, Mira Banjara's cart and Mina Sarki's leather straps constitute distinct occupational storylines.

A trader wants a standardised order for twenty objects and a single invoice under one name. Sonmati separates the price of the first five samples, the extra labour of revising the design, and the return freight for a rejected consignment. Niru agrees to use a shared kiln but not to assume an unseen collective debt; Mira refuses to place her sister's cart beneath a single business mark; and Mina will not guarantee safe carriage of wet straps without testing their load-bearing capacity. These decisions are not prosperity or final commercial victory. They are preliminary achievements in placing definite limits around risk.

There is artistic success in the interdependence of these four trades: materials, transport, design and payment depend on one another, yet the workers do not disappear beneath one trader's leadership, nor are all unemployed people turned into a single moral emblem. Mina strikes out a clause giving the trader complete rights over photographs of the samples and the new design; Sonmati agrees that both names should appear on the test slip for the new strap. Rights at work mean more than cash wages: they also concern samples, intellectual contribution, the risk of defective goods, and the ability to change how work is done. But the trader has not yet agreed to the larger deal; a small private payment arrangement for Niru's five pots has been made, and Sonmati has received an advance for the first five frames. These limited outcomes are essential to the text.

The Water Committee Meeting: The Difference Between an Interview and an Agreement

A hand-drawn line showing the old drainage channel hangs in the water committee's room. A local woman, however, brings her measuring cord and says that the rise of water she has personally witnessed is testimony, not a complete measurement. Tara does not give the map from Videhapur automatic superiority as evidence. Lata asks the assembly about the keeper of the copy bearing the name 'Mithua'. An elderly employee states that he himself saw the slip, but whether Mithua was a child or an adult is information he heard from others. Lata restrains her own urge to turn this immediately into a definite lead. What is agreed upon is only an official time for viewing the original record; there is no guarantee that the original will be found. The search advances because its question has become testable, not because an answer has already been produced.

Tara rereads the five failed conditions of the proposed agreement: the timing of warnings, responsibility when drainage is opened, compensation, access and responses to complaints. The secretary wants agreement at that day's meeting, but the local families refuse to sign before seeing the fields. Tara makes clear that this encounter was an 'interview', not a 'treaty' or binding agreement. From outside the narrative

this might seem a minor distinction of procedure; within the story's structure it anchors the conflict to come. No charter is concluded, local testimony is heard, an objection to the interpreter's remuneration is recorded without stopping the meeting, and a new route to verification is opened. These are the actual outcomes.

The chapter moves in time from the dawn inspection of the boat through the craftsmen's courtyard and the meeting at midday to the veranda in the evening. Focalisation shifts among Tara, Lata, Madhu, Shanti, Kumudi and the women artisans. The final notebook has three entries: the copy of a name, a statement that someone saw a slip, and the appointed time to inspect the original register. It does not say 'Mithun found'. The restraint of this ending is one of the chapter's literary achievements. There is, however, a limitation: almost every dialogue arrives at the intellectual principle of a predetermined evidentiary audit. Boatman, trader, interpreter and the child's mother all offer remarkably lucid, methodical counterarguments; such ideological neatness can sometimes diminish narrative unpredictability and differences of speech. Yet the boat's splinter, a sandal stuck in mud, Shanti's meal, and the material hours of work and fare partly counterbalance that risk.

Chapter 74 — Drona's Due

From an Empty Grain Jar to Humiliation in the Royal Assembly

Chapter 74 opens at dawn with Shanti Bote's unfinished application concerning the payment of her boat fare; immediately afterwards the narration enters a household in the ancient Kuru realm. Two handfuls of grain in Kripi's food jar, Ashwatthama's unfulfilled longing for milk, and Drona's poverty provide the social basis for the question of what is 'owed' to a teacher. Drona's knowledge is valuable, but his hope that Drupada's promise made in the intimacy of their student days will resolve his household's financial distress requires independent examination. Kripi's questions refuse to merge the royal treasury, the affection of a friend, and a personal promise into one category. From the beginning, the moral demand for recompense for instruction is complicated by relationships of public power.

Drupada recognises Drona in the assembly but refuses to treat childhood closeness as equality in present royal authority; he humiliates him publicly. Afterwards Drupada himself realises that an extravagant old promise to share royal land was not a lawful order transferring his subjects' property. That, however, cannot justify humiliating a guest. Through this two-sided criticism, the novel rejects the easy alternatives of making Drona only a heroic victim and Drupada only a wicked king. There is a valid boundary

in Drupada's argument about the duties of kingship, but injustice in his conduct. Drona's humiliation is real, but avenging it cannot automatically become the responsibility of every student. Kripa repeatedly questions precisely this decisive boundary.

The demonstration of skills acknowledges Drona's competence as an instructor. He teaches control of breathing, how the bow should be held, and the granting of a second chance to a struggling pupil. The novel does not seek to dismiss this expertise. Its concern is that someone can be a gifted teacher and still risk transforming private shame into the future warfare of his students. Ashwatthama asks who will recognise the ability of someone who is never admitted at all. This question prepares the Ekalavya motif of Chapter 76. Even before Drona decides what to do, the story makes unequal access to education visible; there is no need to invent additional events in order to demonstrate the regressive consequences.

Shanti's Arrears and the Worker's Freedom of Movement

In the modern temporal strand, Shanti receives different answers at two windows: permission to operate the boat belongs to the water committee, while the fare is the trader's responsibility. A landing-office stamp may demonstrate delivery of the goods, not payment for the carriage. Eventually the officer acknowledges that two sacks were entered in the landing register, while the trader's payment account records only one receipt. The provisional acknowledgement explicitly leaves verification of the claim outstanding. This is positive progress in the evidence, not receipt of the money. Shanti keeps her arrears claim separate from her application for permission to continue crossing the river. Her problem also concerns whether boat work will be stopped while the inquiry is under way. The conflict is as much about 'whose decision may stop my work' as about 'when will I receive the money?'

Asha Bhumij itemises, separately, the displaced mining-area families' housing, transport, medicine, days without livelihoods, and days of schooling lost. An elderly witness testifies to the vehicle he actually saw, not to the possessions inside every home. Asha distinguishes what families report, what receipts record, and what witnesses have observed. A few days' allowance for temporary accommodation is accepted on an interim basis; calculation of permanent compensation remains outstanding. The homeless consequently cease to be merely a numerical total of displacement: each family acquires a particular life composed of time, books, labour and temporary shelter. At times, however, the official's immaculate paperwork and Asha's apparently error-free judgement seem excessively well ordered. By retaining the incompleteness of the actual inquiry, the narrative partly mitigates this limitation.

Chanda Munda is presented with a printed form which would prevent her from obtaining proof of her return home without the contractor's approval. She prepares three distinct applications: notice of leaving the job, a claim for unpaid wages, and identification for travel. Rather than merely stopping a colleague about to sign without reading the words 'all payments received', she explains their meaning. By the twenty-fourth section of the chapter, a procedure has been established for recording a day of leave and obtaining a hearing receipt, but payment of the arrears and travel the following morning are not guaranteed. The worker's body, the worker's earnings, and the worker's mobility are separate rights. This is the central extension of the modern meaning of 'what is owed' in the chapter.

Separate Categories of Identity and Simatirtha's Multilingual Records

Rafiq objects to the conflation of his Surjapuri linguistic identity with his community affiliation in a single digital field. A person's language is not itself a caste name; the narrowness of an office's form does not mean that a person's layered history is absent. Kumudi distinguishes the original linguistic form of an application from the administrative purpose of its translation. The official issues a written acknowledgement of the objection but does not immediately change the form. This is a small decision, yet a tangible check on the institutional pressure to turn assumptions into facts. The stamp on Nasima Shershahbadi's travel slip bearing 'Mechi' is indistinct; demanding correction of an error in a family name does not produce a definitive map of the whole journey. Similarly, the variant reading of Maitri's 'Parola', without a date and details of the issuing authority, is not conclusive evidence of the present route.

These variations in names possess social significance. Rafiq's linguistic independence, the two written forms of Nasima's daughter's name, and Maitri's transport document all meet an office that demands standardisation; the characters ask what kind of source is being used. 'Write it in a single form' may be an administrative convenience, but if treated as ultimate proof of a person, caste, language or place-history, it risks mistaken identification. Kumudi provides linguistic assistance without claiming authority to alter the office's codes. This explicit boundary between an interpreter's knowledge and decision-making power is a central feature of the novel's ethics of evidence.

The Blank Entry for the Teacher's Due: A Contrast Between Two Times

In the final ancient episode, Kripa notices an empty entry for recompense on the training school's register. Drona asserts the right to ask for a teacher's fee, or guru-dakshina, after teaching has been completed. Kripa asks why the pupil should not have the right to understand the limits of

the risk beforehand. In comparison with the modern episodes, Shanti's waiting charge, Chanda's arrears, Asha's interim compensation and Kumudi's fee for interpretation form a conceptual group. They are not, however, the same contract or a single historical event. Drona's wish for revenge remains an unresolved question in the school's account of dues; it would contradict the text to claim that his pupils have already completed the conquest of Drupada in this chapter.

The chapter's temporal arrangement moves in both directions: from a modern dawn to an ancient family and royal assembly; through an extended series of modern offices and markets; back to evening training in the ancient world; and finally towards Lata's gaze at the record room. It is not simply a flashback but a narrational parallel between separate story-worlds. Lata has obtained an appointed time to see the original ledger, not new eyewitness evidence of Mithun. Shanti has an acknowledgement of her claim, not its verification; Asha's families have interim relief, not full compensation; and Chanda has initiated a process for returning home, not received her wages. These incompletions are not necessarily weaknesses of the plot, because the assertion of a right can change an individual's capacity to decide even before a final outcome. One limitation remains: the intense concentration of new characters and occupational disputes within a single day can occasionally reduce their independent depth to the level of brief declarations.

Chapter 75 — The Same Final Digit

The Allure of '7' and the Story of an Illegitimate Conflation

In the old warehouse by the railway square, Naira protects three piles of papers from the dust: the public copy of the official document concerning Mahesh's murder, with private details redacted; transport slips from Simatirtha; and applications concerning school and labour. Their final digit, '7', strikes Kabir as the sign of a single mystery. Naira's first objection is that the same digit does not mean the same account. At this moment the narrative brings the reader's curiosity about criminal coincidence into conflict with fact-based discipline. Mahesh's murder is a verified event. Because such a murder has occurred, it is tempting to make every new clue part of one criminal chain; but that is not evidence. The chapter's title is a critical comment on the illusion of conflation, not an assertion that the papers cannot be distinguished.

The final code of Rajo Bhogta's address, Shiv Dhandi's attendance token, and a slip for a proposed transaction, each ending in seven, belong to three different administrative objects. For a moment Kabir is eager to connect them all; Naira asks for the original ledger, the time of receipt, the purpose

of the entry, and the identity of its holder. The person who compiled the shared phone list drew the information not from the original accounts but from shared images. The resulting compilation is therefore a list of pictures, not proof of a relationship among the sources of a crime. Naira's insistence on separating the motive for Mahesh's murder, the identity of its perpetrator, and the relationship among the documents is a self-critical change learned from her earlier experience of uncontrolled publication.

In a narratologically motivated test, if we formulate the proposition to be established, or sadhya, it would be that 'all three papers belong to the same case'; the proposed reason, or hetu, would be 'their final digit is seven'. Yet that digit recurs in different coding systems, page numbers and tokens, so the required invariable concomitance is not established. Like an inconclusive or anaikantika reason, it cannot establish a criminal connection. This is the critic's analytical comparison, not a claim that the novel contains a complete formal demonstration of narrative inference. The story repeatedly checks the seduction of resemblance without abolishing the right to ask questions. Naira leaves four blank fields for investigation: the original ledger, handwriting, the time of entry, and who stood to benefit. This is not the naming of a criminal but the specification of a future method of inquiry.

Rajo's School, Shiv's Three Days, and Their Distinct Outcomes

Rajo brings her old village address and her current rent receipt to raise a problem concerning school assistance. Because applications from two families have been confused under a single ending code, her daughter faces exclusion from assistance. Rajo makes no claim of uninterrupted residence at the former address; she provides real documentation of the new home. The school eventually offers a temporary arrangement for using books for one week and a date for checking residence. This is not merely a symbolic victory: it somewhat reduces the immediate risk of disruption to her daughter's studies. Full approval of assistance has not yet been obtained. Rajo explicitly opposes dragging her daughter into papers concerning a criminal investigation. The fictitious 'network of number sevens' therefore poses not just an investigative error but an immediate risk to civil rights.

Shiv's five attendance slips differ in their rendering of his name: Dhandi, Dhandi with a variant spelling, and simply Shiv. The dates of work and numbers of sacks agree, but digital payment has been withheld because of the discrepancy in names. Once the original contract account is found, the verified wages for three days are released, while attendance for the other two days awaits reconciliation. Shiv explains that correcting the name is necessary, but the real demand is payment for work performed. The event's outcome is exact: wages for three days have been received; verification of the outstanding two-day claim remains incomplete; and whether the

name difference was intentional alteration or human error is unresolved. Nothing in these mistakes identifies the same culprit as the one who murdered Mahesh.

Beside these two characters stands Rachana Dhimal's mother-tongue class for migrant children. The register's variants 'Tilyuga' and 'Tilyugba' may resemble the story's Tilwaha phonetically, but that does not demonstrate geographical identity. Rather than merely challenge the uniformity of textbooks, Rachana proposes supplementary teaching in the language spoken at home. The school offers an empty classroom two days a week and a proposal for trial remuneration, while permanent approval remains pending. A third family expresses fear that its child's home speech will invite ridicule. Rachana devises a method that starts with pictures and counting to protect the child's linguistic autonomy. Instead of a frictionless celebration of multilingualism, the scene presents embarrassment, inequality, and the practical need for continuity in education.

Medicines: The Meaning of a Word and an Object's Physical Journey

In the original language of a Simatirtha medicine-transport slip, the phrase 'released for dispatch' has become 'received' in the Hindi translation. A computer marks the serial number ending in seven as 'complete', but the hospital storekeeper says that only the information, not the box, has arrived. Maitri Shrestha records separately three stages of transport: the issue of goods, the vehicle's departure, and their actual receipt in the store. Kumudi corrects the original wording and receives identification and payment as translator, but this linguistic correction does not establish that the goods were physically received. Later in the evening the medicine box arrives and its seal matches; one document concerning temperature control, however, remains indistinct, and its suitability for use is left to medical examination.

This episode offers the chapter's most concrete epistemological achievement. A computer's status of 'complete', the word 'received' in a language, the actual presence of a box, and the medicine's fitness for clinical use are four different propositions. Direct perception, information conveyed through words, and institutional records are mutually useful, but one cannot replace another. It has not been shown that someone deliberately mistranslated the phrase in furtherance of a crime; nevertheless, its practical effect reaches the timing of treatment at the hospital. The reader understands here that the discrimination of evidence is not only an intellectual exercise in philosophical debate but a necessity for the patient's body. At Maitri's insistence, Naira does not stop the urgent work of medicine delivery for the sake of her investigation. Her decision

to assign different priorities to inquiry and care in the same hour is a strong sign of moral development.

Number, Privacy, and the Closing of Narrative Time

A broker proposes to Amir Kulhaiya that the money belonging to three families should be sent through a private intermediary under one code. Amir asks for the recipients' separate consent, the fee, the exchange rate, and a written provision for returning funds if the transaction fails. The families choose separate authorised payment channels. Seven appears yet again as a digit, but the principal question concerns the security of receiving money, not Mahesh's murder. Finally Kabir restricts his proposed public list entitled 'The Network of Number Sevens', removes private addresses, and records permission from the owners of the original papers. He has not abandoned the possibility of investigation; he has acquired the restraint not to offer unverified connections to the fire of public accusation.

Lata observes that the heading on the original page bearing 'Mithua' concerns boat materials, weakening the inference that it identifies Mithun. She does not end her search, but carries forward questions about the slip's author and a lawfully obtainable copy. The chapter opens with a dusty pile and a loose nail; at the end Kabir tightens the nail. The repair of the outer window and the removal of unproved connections from the internal list form a subtle compositional parallel. It is not, however, a metaphor declaring Mahesh's murder solved. The sound of the railway continues and human work proceeds along independent lines. A critical limitation is that distinctions among kinds of source recur with extraordinary clarity in the speech of Rajo, Shiv, Maitri, Amir, Lata and Naira alike. So many applications of the same intellectual formula can feel like a textbook lesson. Yet the separate partial outcomes—books for a child, three days' pay for a worker, and a real medicine box for a patient—give that formula human materiality.

Chapter 76 — After Ekalavya

The School Gate and the Social Time of Two Identity Documents

The chapter's first scene is of a new iron post planted beside the school wall. Pratima Rajvanshi stands holding a copy of an old deed of donation, but does not treat it as a final determination of private or public title to the land. The headmaster says that he gave no written permission for private construction; the original survey register remains to be examined. Rajo supports keeping her daughter's school-assistance case separate from the application concerning the footpath leading to school. The right to

education here means not only textbooks inside a classroom but also a safe route to reach it and the continued availability of open ground. Rachana writes the child's words for a boat-picture in the home language and the school's language separately. Such linguistic plurality becomes a sensitive part of the question of access to space, but a child's word is not itself a legal survey of a boundary.

Ramvati Khatwe's former place of residence and her name after marriage appear in different documents. The office wants her to choose one as 'wrong', yet her earlier agricultural labour and her new residence belong to distinct real periods of her life. Erasing the old identity would falsify her earlier wage claim; erasing the new could deprive her daughter of her mother's present relationship in school records. Kumudi explains the discrepancy in translation between 'return' and 'new migration'. Ramvati creates three distinct entries for her working identity, present residence, and wage claim. An old letter preserved by Sarita is returned with Ramvati's permission; Sarita does not claim ownership of its meaning merely because she kept it safe. The office accepts the application and will request the original issuing register, but final legal reconciliation of the two identities has not yet occurred.

Within a single day's narrative time, this episode brings forward several years of women's working history. Ramvati's paddy transplanting, winter repairs of clothing, a few days spent in Sarita's home, and the present application at Simatirtha reveal the multiple temporalities of one life. Against the administration's injunction to 'choose one name', the story upholds the continuity of memory without turning memory alone into definitive legal evidence. The combined contribution of feminist and ethical narratology lies here: a woman possesses her history of embodied labour, but the social responsibility to assemble proof of it is not simply declared to have disappeared.

Ekalavya After the Thumb: Reorganising Education Through the Wound

Amid the episodes in the modern offices, the ninth narrative section returns to Ekalavya in the ancient forest, still bearing the old wound of his thumb. The decisive choice in this rewriting is that he does not simply receive compensation and regain the status of a mighty warrior. Before placing a bow in the hands of a girl named Jhumki, he asks whose wish it is to learn. Her mother has sent her, but Jhumki herself wants to study. The curriculum includes forest paths, safe knots, vessels made from bark, listening, and the measurement of objects. The teacher-pupil relationship rests on the learner's choice, not on unilateral command. This is an independent imaginative continuation within the novel, not a claim

about historically authenticated events following the Ekalavya episode in the original Mahabharata.

An elderly woman who makes ropes subjects even this reimagined Ekalavya to an ethical test. Her name and the price of the rope she supplied are missing from the shared storeroom account. The number of new pupils has increased, but the labour embodied in their materials is becoming invisible. Ekalavya does not immediately declare instruction free; he acknowledges the hours of teaching, the cost of rope, and the shortage of grain. If Jhumki's mother cannot provide materials, another form of exchange for knowledge may be possible, but the mother's agreement must first be sought. When Jhumki fails to notice a fine split in a piece of bamboo, she is not expelled. The cost of the broken material is included among the expenses of instruction. The scene establishes a clear dramatic contrast between the violence of an earlier demand for guru-dakshina and the consent governing a possible future of teaching.

The sharpest moment in Ekalavya's account of himself occurs when he says that he considered Drona his teacher, but Drona's recognition and his own acceptance were not one and the same thing. The sentence raises the question of mutuality in the naming of a teacher-pupil relationship. Jhumki writes her own name in the bark ledger; the elderly woman records the materials. The right to knowledge receives recognition not only from the teacher's seat but also through the presence of the pupil's name. During the night's practice Jhumki learns to recognise signs on her mother's route home. The reader's curiosity shifts from the target of an arrow to the safety of a return home. Here the value of skill lies not in the capacity to inflict harm but in relations that sustain life. Its undertone of compassion arises from the enduring wound of the thumb; the novel does not offer the facile happy ending that one new day of teaching has entirely healed the earlier violence.

Money, Translation, and a Woman's Name in Decision-Making

Binu Darai's seventh money envelope opens the question of distributing earnings from migrant work alongside labour performed within the household. The roof of the house, her father-in-law's medicines, and Binu's possible savings are at issue, but the recipient field names a male guardian. Binu is not demanding that the whole family income be registered in her name. She wants an explicit right to decide over the share that husband and wife have agreed upon. Amir Kulhaiya proposes a written joint instruction but does not fabricate the absent husband's consent. Binu does not altogether reject her mother-in-law's argument about 'the household's money'; she adds the question of whose labour and whose decisions constitute that household. At the end, the family agrees to discuss clear instructions for the next remittance, while the dispute over

previous spending remains unresolved. An old migration document bearing 'Fariyani' does not establish a definitive present-day route: a historical hint and geographical proof are different things.

Somri Hembram's labour contract omits from its translation a clause deducting wages for 'breach of discipline'; responsibility for housing and treatment after an accident is also unclear. The workers' group has authorised her to represent it in obtaining a translation, not to sign on everyone's behalf. Kumudi acknowledges the limits of her knowledge of Santhali, so they decide to seek the help of a trained language assistant and a literate member of the group. One young man, pressed by debt, leans towards accepting the job quickly; other members prefer to wait for the language check. Somri does not compel them all to make one choice. Her strength as a character lies not in the heroism of 'I shall save everyone' but in arranging for an individual's disagreement to be registered under that person's own name.

An old transport document bearing 'Lalbageya' raises the question of credit and fees for translation in Maitri's case. The written name, the unit of distance, and the nature of the goods are separate matters for verification; the text does not prove a definitive route along a present-day road or the temperature suitability of medicines. In response to Pratima's school-land application, the original survey register is requested, the school denies having authorised private construction, and responsibility is accepted for keeping a temporary pedestrian route open. This is not complete victory over land rights: it is a modest decision preserving children's access pending inquiry. The actual thread connecting these different plots is the question, 'Who has the opportunity to change a condition once it has been written down?'

The Achievement of Intertextuality and Its Narrative Limits

In the final sections Naira receives information separately about Ramvati's accepted application, Binu's proposed remittance instructions, Somri's translation review and Pratima's original survey register. She does not proclaim them all to be links in the investigation of Mahesh's murder; the four empty source fields concerning the murder remain empty. Sarita explains plainly that understanding Ekalavya's injury cannot itself settle Ramvati's documents. This is a precise acknowledgement of the novel's intertextual discipline: an ancient narrative gives us a perspective from which to perceive a question; it cannot replace modern evidence.

Jhumki's first mark in Ekalavya's bark ledger, the separate covers of Ramvati's two identity papers, Binu's savings notebook, Somri's collective language meeting and Pratima's public path all make the 'right to have one's name written down' a recurring material concern. Narrative time

moves among a modern morning, a day of learning in the ancient forest, a modern evening and a brief report at night. Focalisation is distributed among Pratima, Ramvati, Ekalavya, Jhumki, Binu, Somri and Naira. The arrival of so many characters in a single chapter provides social breadth, but can leave too little time within scenes for each one's psychological depth. The unusual clarity of argumentative statements may also diminish the natural hesitations of dialogue. Nevertheless, Jhumki's broken bamboo, the sealed thread belonging to Somri's child, and the household work of Binu's mother-in-law drying grain give the conceptual pattern an embodied life.

Drona Parva / Sundara Kanda: Comparative Criticism of Chapters 73–76

The Sequence of Events and a Map of Unfinished Decisions

The event-structure of these first four chapters is not a simple ascent towards resolution. In Chapter 73, decisions are made about travel safety; a two-meeting contract is arranged with the interpreter; artisans agree on trial consignments; and a time is fixed for consulting the original register containing 'Mithua'. No agreement is concluded by the water committee. In Chapter 74, an acknowledgement is issued for Shanti's claim concerning two sacks, Asha obtains interim help with accommodation, Chanda submits separate applications concerning departure and wages, and Rafiq receives acknowledgement of his linguistic objection. Arrears, permanent resettlement and changes to the form remain outstanding. In Chapter 75, Shiv receives wages for three days, Rajo's daughter obtains temporary access to books for a week, a medicine box arrives but remains subject to temperature-suitability testing, and the proposed criminal connection based on a shared digit remains unsubstantiated. In Chapter 76, Ramvati's documentary application is accepted, the original land survey for Pratima's school is requested, new procedures are arranged concerning Binu's consent to remittances and Somri's contract translation, and the experiment of Ekalavya's new class begins. It is essential to distinguish acknowledgement, verification, interim acceptance, payment, and final decision throughout this sequence.

Drona, Ekalavya, and a Reinterpretation of Rights

Drona's poverty is real and Drupada's humiliation of him actually occurs. The novel nevertheless asks where the justification of a teacher's fee breaks down when it is turned into an unlimited instrument for avenging a teacher's humiliation. After Ekalavya's loss of his thumb, the new school attended by Jhumki offers a possible critical answer: the learner's wish

governs admission, the cost of materials is recognised, imperfect skill is met with further instruction, and the teacher-pupil relationship requires mutual acknowledgement. This intertext transforms the narrative categories inherited from the Mahabharata; it does not assert that it is providing a historically exact continuation of the older text. Stories of the modern boatman, interpreter, worker, schoolchild and craftswoman give this ancient pattern particular bodies, times and prices. The Ramayana's 'Sundara Kanda' functions here as a broad structural designation. The text does not support describing an independent ancient scene with Hanuman as the principal event in these four chapters.

Narrative Discrimination, Story Time, and the Limits of Multiple Voices

Every unjustified leap is a type of insufficient reasoning: inferring Mithun's identity from an equipment ledger marked 'Mithua'; a common crime from the digit '7'; full payment from the boat's stamp; clinical receipt from a dispatch message about medicine; the final boundary of school land from a copy of a donation deed; or the invalidity of present labour from an old premarital name. Not all the evidence, however, belongs to the same category. Sometimes the meaning of a word is uncertain, sometimes direct observation is limited, sometimes the link between sources is severed, and sometimes a legal decision is still pending. The vocabulary of narrative inference is the critic's analytical method; the elaborate propositions of the classical philosophical treatises are not literally present in every conversation. This strand makes narrative plurality possible by granting distinct domains of authority to a local boatman's practical knowledge, an interpreter's linguistic knowledge, a mother's personal experience, and a physician's expertise.

An exacting artistic objection nevertheless arises. When character after character states the correct category of evidence and the ideal ethical boundary with perfect clarity in every dispute, the social diversity of their voices risks being overlaid by ideological uniformity. The mere presence of many professions is not proof of fully achieved Bakhtinian polyphony. Genuine polyphony requires that the characters' divergent values, objections and outcomes remain alive beyond the narrator's final supposedly correct answer. Sonmati's delayed earnings, Niru's fear of debt, the risk taken by Somri's indebted young colleague in choosing immediate work, Rajo's daughter's urgent need of books, and Lata's continuing search keep that possibility open. The novel's most successful scenes are often those in which objects—a cracked boat plank, a rope, a receipt, the seal of a medicine box, broken bamboo—appear before the argument.

Achievement, Critical Counterargument, and the Questions Ahead

Together the four chapters extend the first configuration of the Drona Parva from a warrior-teacher's commands to the conditions of access in everyday life. The investigation after Mahesh's death remains open, but the days of all the families have not become mere subplots of the murder case. This expansion is part of the work's social strength. A limitation is that the connection between almost every ancient and modern sequence is philosophically transparent to excess, sometimes reducing the spontaneous tension of narrative uncertainty. Even so, the ambiguity of Lata's 'Mithua' ledger, Drona's unresolved claim to guru-dakshina, the medicine's temperature examination, Ramvati's original issuing register, and Shiv's two unpaid days sustain important unanswered questions. The criticism of the next chapters must ask whether these questions develop causal continuity in the characters' lives or merely produce the receipt of new files.

Chapter 77 — Trijata's Message

A Sentence Heard in the Ashoka Grove: News, Apprehension, and Narrative Reliability

The chapter opens in the Ashoka grove of ancient Lanka, with a leaf breaking between Sita's fingers and the stronger vein of another leaf. This is not simply an adornment of a sorrowful setting. The distinction between a leaf's fragility and a strand that survives resembles the difference between uncertain whispers about a war and verified news. An ambiguous sentence spoken by one guard becomes certainty in another's mouth. The fundamental narrative event is not what has happened on the battlefield; it is the transformation of uncertain information into definitive language. Sita asks 'Who saw it?' and 'From whose mouth did the people at the gate hear it?' The sequence of questions seeks the chain of sources through which the news has travelled; the guard cannot give evidence. The story does not share an omniscient account of the battle's outcome with the reader, either. Thus the reader's knowledge is ethically connected with Sita's vulnerability without being identical to it.

Trijata says she heard two attendants in the royal palace disagreeing over news of the fighting. She possesses neither a written message nor direct testimony from someone who saw the battlefield. This acknowledgement of her limits does not weaken the credibility of her account; it makes the account more trustworthy, because she does not confuse what she heard with what was witnessed. Sita's question—'If you are so uncertain, why did you come to tell me?'—presents a genuine counterargument. Even cautious news may increase the suffering of a captive woman. Trijata replies that she

had to challenge the guard's unfounded certainty. The ethics of truth is consequently not a simple moral prescription to choose between 'say nothing at all' and 'repeat everything that has been heard'. It demands judgement between the harm potentially caused by false certainty and the limited usefulness of uncertain information.

Listening to the sound of drums, Trijata explains that sound alone cannot establish victory, defeat or mourning. Sita observes that the ground beneath the grove, its trees and Trijata's face are things she has directly experienced; the condition of the person she loves is not. Focalisation enters the interior of Sita's fear without proclaiming the fear a fact about the war. Her small act of drinking barley gruel is a significant 'embodied event': Sita refuses to abandon the care of her body because the news is uncertain. Trijata's song is not a prophecy either; it is an affective medium of companionship. It is appropriate to discuss the partial effect of karuna rasa, the aesthetic mood of compassion, and the feeling of friendship in this scene. To assume that singing verifies the report, however, would make rasa in Indian poetics a substitute for evidence.

A Register of Events and the Narrative Arrangement of Two Times

The sequence of events in the ancient strand is limited but clear: a guard turns an ambiguous statement about the battle into certainty; Sita asks for its source; Trijata identifies the limits of her hearsay; it becomes clear that no written order has arrived; Sita suspends judgement; and Trijata acknowledges that even an attempt at verification may fail. Here 'suspending judgement' is not passivity: it is the protection of one's autonomy in the face of uncertain news. Choosing to mend cloth with a torn leaf and finally touching a knot of thread create a material recurrence. The knot holds, but Sita is not reassured: keeping the work of the body and objects going does not end the world's crisis. The final return to the Ashoka grove does not complete a perfectly closed circle; it reopens the ethical question of contemporary events within the ancient scene.

In the ninth narrative section the story moves to contemporary Videhapur, returning to the ancient grove in the twenty-eighth. This movement back and forth does not present the ancient period as 'historical proof'; rather, it becomes a conceptual echo of modern disputes over evidence. In the modern sequence, the amendment to Amala's name affects the separate entitlements of three families; the meaning of a page signed by Hira is disputed; Nasima's daughter obtains provisional permission to attend class; Rafiq's two versions of a river name and Binu's word 'Sir' on an income document belong to independent contexts. No single criminal cause has been established among these episodes. Through this multi-situational structure the reader sees several social consequences of one question: does telling someone that a matter was 'understood' prove that person's consent?

The files of the different characters nevertheless retain their separate limits.

Amala's Application for Correction: Separate Persons Within a Collective

Amala Sarbariya keeps three applications in separate covers, tied with red thread. The incorrect combination of names has brought three distinct administrative injuries: suspension of school assistance, renewed verification of an employment register, and loss of an earlier receipt number. The employee's proposal to 'standardise everything in one place' sounds like administrative efficiency, but Amala asks whether the error will be corrected or a human being replaced. Their collective petition contains no private family particulars; it requests comparison of the original handwritten copies with the printed list, written reasons for amendments, and continuity of the old dates. Dates are not merely a calculation here: reducing time already spent to zero by demanding an entirely new application is a form of administrative violence.

A ward representative proposes to sign for everyone. Amala accepts help with photocopying and accompaniment but does not relinquish the right to decide. The achievement of the narrative is not to deny collective organisation but to protect the right of individual self-expression within it. The actual outcome is a written direction to locate the original list and provisional protection for the order of the three families' receipt numbers, not a conclusion that every name has already been fully corrected. In the twenty-sixth section, while tending the hearth at home, Amala says over the phone that the office must first compare the copies already available and summon a family on a definite date only if testimony is truly necessary. From the perspective of social history, this carries considerable weight: waiting, travel, abandoned work and domestic fuel are the real costs of administrative error. Yet the independent first-person voices of the three families remain limited; Amala's judgement as their representative compresses a broader range of lived experiences. That is a possible artistic contraction.

Hira's Signature, Nasima's Language, and the Distribution of Knowledge

Hira Meche accepts that his signature physically appears on the document but does not know whether the clause declaring 'no objection to long-term use' was actually read aloud to him. Two passages bearing the same date do not constitute acceptance of the same meaning. The first concerns testing a temporary route; the second concerns future permanent rights. 'The signature exists' is a matter of direct reading, but the proposition that

'the complete meaning was understood' requires independent reasons involving translation, the procedure of reading it aloud, and explicit consent. In the vocabulary of narrative inference, treating a signature as sufficient proof overlooks a necessary condition, or upadhi. The request to suspend implementation until a new hearing is granted; the earlier contract is not annulled. Hira also refuses to sign a new withdrawal form without understanding it. He is not hostile to paperwork; he is opposed to meaningless consent.

Nasima Shershahbadi's daughter approaches school afraid that her speech will be mocked. Nasima draws attention to the difference between the local pronunciation of her name and its official written form, while the required transfer certificate has still not arrived. The girl receives permission to attend classes for a week on an interim basis; final admission is pending. A complaint about mockery of her language is registered separately, but the name of the child accused of the mockery is not published before inquiry. Nasima is an artisan who repairs the bindings of library books; she also asks for an application form for adult education. Through this delicate choice the novel does not conflate skilled labour with formal literacy, yet establishes a relationship of social respect between them. The daughter writing her own name is not an incidental sentimental embellishment. It is a visible answer to the question of who has authority over a name's pronunciation and writing.

River Names, an Income Document, and Critical Boundaries

The similarity of the sounds in Rafiq's spoken 'Saura' and an old official page's 'Saura' written differently does not establish that they identify the same river in geographical fact. Kabir removes 'confirmed match' from his draft and replaces it with 'investigation of variant readings'. The word 'Sir' in Binu Darai's document concerning migrant earnings may be a place name, but no map accompanies it. Binu clarifies that correcting the name will not automatically release money that has been withheld. In both episodes the narrator maintains a fine distinction between textual comparison and the allocation of rights. Recording the name and remuneration of the translator is important because the labour involved in producing knowledge should not remain anonymous.

At the chapter's close Naira prepares a list of five distinct cases, keeping the file on Mahesh's murder closed separately; no new direct evidence about the murder is found that day. This negative finding illustrates the narrative's restraint. A limitation must nonetheless be recognised in a fuller assessment: almost every character repeatedly states the principles 'what I saw, I saw' and 'what I heard, I heard' with astonishing procedural clarity. Repetition brings the moral firmness of the writing into relief, but may reduce the naturalness of speech, differences of language between

characters and spontaneous surprise. The ancient leaf, Amala's hearth, Hira's dust-covered measuring rope, Nasima's needle and Binu's mother-in-law peeling potatoes restore flesh and life to the potentially dry argument. The achievement is the continuously protected right to ask questions; the limit is that their answers are often organised as theory before they have emerged through the plot.

Chapter 78 — Mandodari's Household

A Bronze Vessel in the Royal Household and the Inner Geography of Public Hunger

The first scene is composed of a cracked bronze vessel and the measuring of rice inside Lanka's royal household. The external events of war and the distribution of food within the home are two temporal rhythms of the same house. Mandodari's question is not only how much is available. It asks whose plates are first deprived and whose names are erased in the empty lines of a register. The royal family's meals remain unchanged while blanks appear beside the names of outside attendants: the contrast becomes a visible figure of social hierarchy. Mandodari first asks for her own portion to be examined, but this is not simply an act of personal generosity; it is an initial demand that the method of distribution be made public. The instruction to give the injured guard's wife proof of receipt for medical treatment exposes the distance between royal orders and what actually takes place at the doorway. The novel makes room within its history of kingship for a woman who watches how an order is implemented.

Trijata repeats to Mandodari the uncertain news of war heard in the Ashoka grove. Mandodari's question, however, moves beyond 'What news has Sita been told?' and turns war into a question of social accusation. A young woman of the royal household calls the captive Sita a woman from the side that is increasing the danger. Mandodari replies that a woman brought by force cannot be made responsible for Ravana's decision. This is an ethical turning point in the narrative: loyalty to one's nearest family does not automatically entail endorsement of state action. The young woman's fear remains real, and the story does not instantly convert it into ideological agreement. Mandodari rejects a proposal to mark a servant as suspicious for questioning the war. 'Asks too many questions' is not proof of a crime. This foundational rule links the ancient episode to the violence of records throughout the modern narrative.

Mandodari urges Ravana to return Sita and not to punish soldiers' families for their fears; Ravana rejects the request and leaves. This is a successful presentation of a woman's voice, not a victory over royal policy. The

narrator clearly delineates her restricted power: she may alter arrangements for medicine, food and rest, but not the decision to continue the war. Assigning distinct accounting responsibilities to an elderly woman distributing food and another woman carrying news to a wounded soldier's household goes beyond conventional praise of a goddess-like character's 'compassion'. When she gives bread to Trijata, Mandodari asks that the kindness not be publicised. This negative command asks whose story a powerful benefactor wishes to claim under her own name. At the same time, Mandodari becomes the centre of excessively righteous pronouncements. Her possible internal conflict, the sustained psychological pressure of the royal household and the independent voice of the food distributor receive comparatively little development.

Misinformation at a Modern School: A Register of Corrections

In the tenth narrative section, the return from the ancient royal house becomes a glass noticeboard at a contemporary school. Asad Sayyad finds that an accusatory line about a 'suspect nomadic group' was added to the first public notice concerning the safety of a missing child. Its source, date and receipt number are absent. The statement reduces the number of customers visiting Mohan Kanjar, and he receives a warning not to bring his cart near children. The circulation of information here is not merely a matter of mental prejudice: it produces a direct loss of earnings in the marketplace. Mohan does not offer a 'certificate of innocence' covering every hour of the day; he asks only for such records of purchases and payments as can be obtained from a shop selling wheel components.

The original file for Sajid Nat's performance rehearsal states that the children's faces must not be made public. Lata has found the heading 'Mithua' in a boat-shed record, but it has not been turned into Mithun's personal name. The headmistress compares the original notice ledger and finds no identifiable 'local source' for the disputed addition. The sequence of events is consequently precise: discovery of an unauthorised sentence of accusation; comparison with the original record; decision to remove the incorrect page; preparation of a revised public statement; and acknowledgement that the old video still survives on phones. Removing an incorrect page and undoing the social effects of an accusation already spread are two different outcomes. Asad's insistence that a false public statement requires a public correction becomes an ethical centre of the novel.

One parent protests, 'A child is missing, and you are correcting words.' This counterargument deserves to be read seriously: the urgency of finding the child is real. Asad and Lata explain that an unproven accusation against an entire community could divert the search down a false path.

Audio from an unidentified voice supplied by a parent is treated not as 'testimony' but as a separate lead requiring investigation. Mohan even narrows the headmistress's proposal to write 'innocent': finding the available basis for an accusation to be false does not mean that every aspect of his life has undergone investigation. This demanding caution gives artistic form to a contemporary ethics of information, but here too the dialogue risks sounding like a social worker's briefing. The story balances it with specific details of damaged livelihoods and the reproduction of misinformation.

Fish, Looms, Meat Shops, and the Politics of Collective Accusation

At the afternoon market, an attempt is made to associate Kamlesh Khatik's red-striped stage material with a suspicious consignment solely on the basis of colour. Kamlesh presents his purchase invoice and the school's usage slip separately. Of the five yards of cloth purchased, four were used on the stage and one was folded along the edge. Mira testifies to no more than she personally saw. The artisan's measurement ledger supports the difference in use, but does not establish the source of all cloth of that colour or the real owner of goods elsewhere. A proposal to withdraw the collective accusation is raised in committee, with the final signature still pending. To accuse 'the Khatiks' as a community substitutes a general allegation for examination of a particular object; the narrative methodically exposes the substitution.

Mira Banjara's sister retains control over her time and customers even while participating in shared transport arrangements. The word 'Supain' in an old notebook may refer to a halt on a journey or a mark identifying a customer; it cannot alone be used to draw a river map. A communal hearth and independent business accounts coexist. The chapter thus prevents the mistake of equating collective life with a single form of economic ownership. The original copies of Ramvati Khatwe's two identity documents return from the office, but their administrative reconciliation is still pending. The unverified geography of the word 'Santi' is not automatically 'corrected' into a river. Her private letter remains confidential. The essential relationship among the three episodes is that resemblance of names, similarity of colour, or sharing means of travel does not in itself create criminal association or a relationship of ownership.

The possible shape of Videha Parallel History in this chapter emerges outside the history of royal warfare: Mohan's wheel, Kamlesh's measurement, Mira's transport and Ramvati's original papers all become evidence of lives. 'Parallel', however, must mean more than extending a list of names. The decisive question is whether the characters alter their decisions and whether authority accepts or evades those decisions. Mohan's customers have not returned; Kamlesh's proposal remains pending; the

sister has recorded her separate fare; and Ramvati has recovered her original papers. These are different levels of outcome. A comprehensive moral victory would be an unwarranted declaration.

Two Temporal Strands, Reading Pace, and Critical Counterargument

The transition from ancient Lanka to the modern school does not imply a historical relationship of cause and effect; it constructs a parallel of ideas. Mandodari's food register and the school's false notice are different documents. In both episodes, women and marginalised people whose lives are affected by royal or institutional statements question those statements; that commonality cannot erase the distinct forms of violence in the two periods. Within the modern strand, focalisation shifts rapidly among Mohan, Lata, Kamlesh, Mira and Ramvati. The narrator usually limits knowledge through external scenes and dialogue. The reader is not told Ravana's final inner motive or the identity of the person who inserted the line into the viral notice.

At the chapter's end a revised statement is posted at the school. The previous false copy is not destroyed; it is preserved as archival evidence. This is an important transformation: correcting an error does not mean erasing its history. Lata asks separately for the date and details of the official involved in Mithun's search, insisting that her son's name must not become a publicity symbol. An artistic limitation recurs: the grain in the royal household, the school notice, the measuring of stage cloth, transport, and two identity documents produce so many consecutive inquiries that the intensity of Mandodari's central story may become dispersed. It would be a mistake to praise this dispersal uncritically as 'polyphony'; some lives carry more complex uncertainties and some documentary procedures are less dramatic. Nevertheless, the story's restraint in holding together a correction of a false public statement and the still-continuing search for a child is a notable achievement of the chapter.

Chapter 79 — The Resemblance of Faces

A Wet Mat and Two Cropped Pictures: The Visual Grammar of Rumour

The chapter opens with Sarayu shaking out a wet mat beneath the railway bridge. Water, the mat, and the muddy current are not simply colours of the landscape; they are the material conditions of unstable shelter, repeated soaking, and daily reconstruction. At that moment her granddaughter shows her two cropped women's faces on a phone, beneath which a frightening sentence associates them with taking away a child. The first picture has been cut from an old scene at the forest gate; the second from an uncertain scene behind a goods train. Whether the second image shows a child or a sack is unclear. The original narrative disruption is not a directly witnessed kidnapping. It is the conversion of two unrelated scenes into a public accusation under the same fear-inducing caption. The granddaughter's question, 'Is this a picture of my grandmother too?' brings social violence into the privacy of a home.

Janaki stops the suggestion that the phone be snatched away: copies have already circulated. Naira asks separately about the limits of the two women's consent. Sarayu does not want her face or any identifying detail of her home published; Janaki wants no fresh photograph, a response at a public meeting, and the file concerning the search for Mithun kept separate. The women in this scene are not represented by a single collective manifesto: Sarayu, Janaki, the granddaughter, and the women later unloading goods each possess distinct rights. The refusal to mistake the moment when a photograph reaches a phone for the moment when it was taken is a subtle achievement in the handling of narrative time. The present of viral circulation and the past of the recorded event cannot simply be made to leap into each other.

Sajid Nat brings the original card from his acting rehearsal; the other original phone used at the forest gate is not with him but with the young man who holds it. The young man shows the old, unbroken footage: the wet gate, Durga's bamboo knot, Tulsi's grain cart, and Janaki's two families. There is no scene of anyone seizing a child. Yet no answer has emerged as to who added the false caption to the cropped image. The ethics of the investigation consists in not declaring the young man guilty of the edited accusation merely because he made the recording. Here the original scene, cropped frame, caption, and recirculation become four different narrative levels. This is not metanarrative in the formal sense, but the process by which images are produced becomes an object of criticism within the story.

The Limits of Analogy and Evidence of Independent Identity

One person insists that a face resembling Sarayu's must belong to the same person; Mira Mandal questions the probative force of identifying features —the end of a sari, the angle of a nose, and the inclination of the body. The reflection on analogy linked to the earlier Ekalavya/gavaya episode takes an interesting turn here: resemblance can provide one route to understanding an unfamiliar object, but it cannot conclusively establish that two women are one and the same person. In the terms of Nyaya reasoning, the proposition under examination is that 'the woman in the second picture is Sarayu,' and what is to be established is identity of person. 'Visual resemblance' does not furnish an adequate reason, for a similar headcloth, blurred focus, incomplete timing, and different locations are possible limiting conditions (upadhis). A combined examination of date, place, uninterrupted sequence, and independent testimony is needed. It would be wrong to present this application as a verbatim dialogue from the classical Tattvacintamani: the novel employs a mode of reasoning creatively in relation to modern visual evidence.

Padma traces the source of the second picture but does not assume the right to open the entire contents of a private phone. The woman in the old loading yard is not identified publicly without her consent; she is willing to give her own statement to a designated officer. The unbroken original recording shows the labour of unloading baskets, folding sacks, and wiping sweat from the forehead. Its date is checked not merely against the accountant's account but against an installation receipt, a woman worker's fare slip, and the sequence of recordings. Thus the second picture does not show the forest-gate scene, and the description of it as child abduction remains unproven. But the actual means or person responsible for linking the two faces is still unknown. Proof of 'mistaken identity' and identification of the 'maker of the false accusation' are separate objectives of inquiry.

Sarayu asks when her granddaughter will return to school. The question exposes the limits of the inquiry's rational achievement: finding the original recording does not immediately remove the child's fear. Mira gives the time of the next class, and the family will choose a safe route. The causal sequence of the social narrative does not end at 'the photograph has been proved false'; the longer consequences for reputation and access to education continue to have a life of their own. At the chapter's end the granddaughter asks whether her grandmother's face now belongs to her grandmother again. Sarayu replies that her face never belonged to anyone else: the mistake was made by those who put a name on the paper. This emotional answer is figurative, not a legal declaration. The distinction

between a person's self-identity and an identity imposed by society is contained in a brief domestic exchange.

Fish Stalls, Outstanding Cloth Payments, and the Ethics of Inspection

From the eleventh textual segment onward, the story moves into a new dispute over the fish-market contract. Vinod Kevart questions the line for 'miscellaneous charges' imposed on small vendors. Phulmati Tiyar separates the purchase price of fish, the labour of making nets, and the cleaning and selling work of two young women. A proposal to mark out three stalls for part-time vendors on a one-week trial basis is accepted; final approval of measurements, cleaning, and fees remains outstanding. The distinction between 'stalls have been allotted' and 'permanent market rights have been established' is indispensable to an overall assessment. The contractor displays his drainage-repair expenses, but the question of where the daily fees collected from small sellers went remains unresolved. From the standpoint of social history, the 'market' is not merely a merchant's contract; it is also the time available for meals in the home of a woman who sells fish for part of the day.

Gita Kori and Saraswati from across the border examine the measurement of bolts of cloth, the company mark applied without the weavers' consent, the cost of yarn advanced, and the separately outstanding wages. The signature on a receipt received on Saraswati's phone has not yet been authenticated. Three parties agree on a date for supplying copies of the accounts; no money has been received. Gita refuses to treat Yusuf's red-cord bundle as her company's goods merely because the colour matches. This restraint in making a proprietary claim prepares the resulting state of affairs in Chapter 80. Gita retains her autonomy as a worker, but neither the full extent of her financial constraint nor the detailed law governing the cross-border contract is supplied in the text; it would be improper to invent an external legal conclusion.

A routine health inspection at Farida Qureshi's meat shop complicates the chapter's social counterpoint to a community-based boycott. Farida does not dismiss every criticism as prejudice. She accepts that one strip used in cleaning genuinely needs replacing and makes the correction at once. The sample-test result is still pending, as is the chairperson's signature withdrawing the boycott notice. An impartial reading must recognise that, although collective boycotts grounded in caste or religion are improper, individual food-safety inspections remain necessary. The inspector's limited report is neither final proof of innocence nor justification for a humiliating collective verdict. At this level, the narrative's ethics avoids a mechanical division between villains and heroes.

Public Retraction, Private Time for Grief, and Formal Criticism

At the public hearing, the different sources of the two original pictures are made clear. None of the available images constitutes evidence that Mithun was present or that a child was taken away. Janaki demands an explicit withdrawal of the image-based accusation against her group, not a vague statement such as 'there may have been some confusion.' The school, Asad, and market representatives prepare a joint retraction. Janaki hears it read and signs it, but does not permit all the group members' names to be published. This is the chapter's decisive completed event. A separate date is fixed for inquiry into Mithun's disappearance; the child is not found. Sarayu's standing in the market is not immediately restored. Naira maintains three separate files: the false collective accusation, Mithun's disappearance, and the various outstanding market dues. A shared vehicle remains only a possible question for investigation, not proof of a shared crime.

The chapter is organised as a single day from the morning's wet mat to the evening meal, but many older images, papers, and future hearings enter that day. Its narrative density feels considerable because its thirty-one textual segments contain seven or eight subepisodes; that density should be assessed by the quality of its eventful turns, not by the narrative's figure of 10.8 change-signals per thousand words. Focalisation moves from Sarayu, Janaki, and Naira to Vinod, Gita, and Farida. The advantage is that the social cost of accusation becomes widely visible; the limitation is that some workers' distinct idioms become assimilated into the same carefully deliberated grammar of evidence. Nevertheless, the wet mat, water from melting ice, measuring cord, cleaning at the meat shop, and granddaughter's question prevent the chapter from turning into a lecture on applied justice: they make it a living story-world.

Chapter 80 — The Weaver's Second Account

The Making of Two Ledgers: Separating Actual Goods from Goods under Allegation

At dawn, Yusuf Ansari joins the broken threads of his loom. The knot pressed down with a fingernail offers a visible instance of the experienced worker's direct knowledge. His standing in the market has become precarious because the customer's white length of cloth and a disputed second bundle tied with red cord have been confused in a single ledger. In the first account Yusuf records the measurement of the cloth, credit advanced for yarn, and wages; in the second he records the detained consignment, the shop's stamp, the allegation, and the costs of investigation. This 'second account' should not be read as deception or concealed trade, but as a creative object distinguishing categories of evidence. Two pages may physically touch without their contents thereby acquiring identical ownership. Yusuf's son proposes photographing the woven join and retaining its date. Yusuf accepts these as supporting evidence, not as a complete substitute for knowledge acquired through touching the loom.

Urmila Rajak demands that her work not be declared criminal merely because laundered and suspect fabrics were loaded on the same cart. Mahendra, the carter, produces the entry register for his vehicle but does not claim to know the origin of every load. Separate tables for ownership, transportation, and complaints are installed in the goods depot: a material staging of the novel's method. Here the narrative poses its decisive question: at what point does a document establishing use of the same cart become necessary proof of ownership of the goods or of a crime? It does not. A shared cart does not make objects, persons, and intentions identical. In this chapter the classification of evidence is not a written homily alone; it yields concrete consequences for permission to open goods, deductions from wages, and the suspension of sales.

The first bundle is opened in the presence of authorised witnesses. Yusuf recognises the earth-coloured join in his weaving; the customer's original order specifies fabric for domestic curtains, not a hospital supply. The customer testifies to the order, advance, and intended use, but cannot himself identify the minute woven join. These distinct forms of expertise complement one another. The second bundle carries a claim of approval in a hospital's name, yet the hospital register produced contains no approval corresponding to that period and document number. The employee states plainly that failure to find approval in the record does not establish who made the stamp or what the bundle contains. Both the name and the evidence behind Shekhar's alleged telephone instruction remain

incomplete. Distribution of the second bundle remains suspended because approval is unverified—not because Yusuf has been proved a thief.

Register of Events: Detention, Correction, and Limited Release

The central sequence develops as follows: the customer expresses fear that the first length of cloth will not be returned → Yusuf separates the accounts for the two consignments → the original order and the weaving of the first length are matched in the presence of witnesses → the absence of the alleged hospital approval for the other bundle is established in the register → the second bundle's seal, weight, and statements are recorded → a release document for the first length is prepared, but mistakenly prints 'all goods released' → Yusuf has this erroneous universal statement removed → only the first length is released, while detention of the other continues. The decisive success in the original story is not that 'all allegations were withdrawn', but that a written administrative and quasi-judicial boundary, specific to the object concerned, replaces an erroneous collective decision. The customer takes the measurements for the curtains at home; the object reaches its actual use. In this outcome the bodily labour of Yusuf is restored from an abstract file to an object within a household.

Mahendra fears losing wages for the time required to issue a separate receipt for a load carried on the shared cart. Vinod advises him to record waiting time, stoppage, and the cart-owner's instructions separately; the wage claim remains independent. At this point the narrator also exposes the price of a solution: a new investigative procedure may itself impose additional costs on workers. Yusuf is willing to pay for the actual transport of the first length, but does not want the cost of detaining the second unfairly placed on his shoulders. Administrative time is needed to distinguish responsibility, whereas the time of hunger cannot be suspended. Without the collision of these two temporalities, the story would be incomplete.

Rahim, Sakina, and the Independent Claim of Labour

The dispute involving Rahim Mansuri's register of seven mattresses and four sacks of carded cotton becomes linked with Yusuf's textile story, but it is not declared a second criminal case. Rahim opposes opening the mattresses without the customer's permission, protecting the limits of ownership. The date of the allegation and the time of carriage remain distinct questions for investigation. His appeal is admitted; no final order removing the allegation has been passed. His wife decides to accept a new order and demands her own name appear in the costs of a separate consignment note. This is an explicit objection to reducing women's

labour to incidental family assistance. Her husband adds her name to the appeal—a small but verified change in the character.

Sakina, the dyer, makes visible the problem of 'one object, labour performed twice': a length of cloth first dyed indigo and then changed to green and purple. The thumb impression on the customer's written alteration slip is doubtful. Sakina testifies that she heard the oral request, but calls the customer back for confirmation. The customer agrees to pay part of the wages for the new colour, with a date set for testing the remainder. The old debt has not been forgiven, nor have the full dues for the changed colour been paid; seasonal testing of durability also remains outstanding. Here accounting is the result of a living conversation. The customer, an opposing party, is not instantly rendered unjust merely because independent testimony becomes available: there is experiential ground for the fear that the colour may fade, although a full test has not taken place. This carefully qualified counter-position keeps the narrative at some distance from pure sermonising.

At the fish market Vinod and Phulmati take new measurements of three sections of a temporary walkway. Ice-water, rainwater, and silt from the drain produce different problems at the same location. A small measurement cannot disclose the entire ecology of a river. The temporary walkway remains operational for one week, while final authority over shade and cleaning is unresolved. Lakhan Satar, Chandru, and Bela have carried the wooden planks; wages appear in the contractor's bill, but the workers' own register describes their contribution as 'free community service'. Bela insists that her hours and quantity of work be counted separately, and refuses the deletion of her name under the designation 'Lakhan's companion'. The original wage register is requisitioned, but no payment has been made. In both subordinate plots, 'community' can become a term of power concealing economic inequality; the novel opens the term to expose differences in profit, labour, and risk.

Narrative Time, Material Sensation, Evidence, and the Unresolved Final Question

Late in the day Yusuf delivers the first length of cloth to its customer; his son prevents the customer's private name from being publicly circulated. The son's training fees, the yarn debt, and losses remain outstanding. Identification of the second bundle and Shekhar's statement are incomplete. The closing scene reaches Lata's household, the memory of Mithun's kurta, and Naira's separately maintained murder-investigation file. A few stopping places named on the freight route coincide with names in an old missing-person slip: this suggests a possible question for inquiry, not a proved link to abduction. No new name appears in the

documentation for Mahesh's murder inquiry on the day of this commercial hearing. This restraint matters particularly: the narrator resists the easy attraction of forcibly combining the many plotlines of a long novel into one 'grand conspiracy'.

In formal terms, the feel of the loom, the earth-coloured join, red cord, wet transport slip, ice-water, and bodily marks of carrying planks deepen the density of the story-world. Almost every material thing acts on two planes: as a visible object and as a possible means of proof. Descriptive breadth allows an extensive everyday social history to emerge. A weakness must nevertheless be acknowledged: the prolonged succession of hearings across textual units 4–25 may make the novel resemble a series of case notes; characters frequently explain technical distinctions in remarkably well-ordered language. Such exposition increases intellectual clarity about cause and consequence but may reduce the possibilities of hesitation, silence, and unexpected human inconsistency. The final domestic window, the customer's curtains, Rahim's wife's voice, and Bela's dissent soften this structural rigidity. The principal literary achievement is not that the crime has been solved; it is that distinct objects, labour, and people, submerged beneath a false collective accusation, can again become independent stories.

Drona Parva / Sundara Kanda: Joint Critical Assessment of Chapters 77–80

Event Map of the Four Chapters

In Chapter 77, Trijata does not treat reported war news as definitive truth; the earlier order of receipt for Amala's three families is provisionally protected; a request to suspend implementation of Hira's disputed consent until rehearing is accepted; Nasima's daughter is provisionally permitted to sit in class; and the names of the rivers remain subject to verification. In Chapter 78, Mandodari unsuccessfully urges Ravana to return Sita; the modern school publicly corrects a false collective accusation, but Mithun is not found; Kamlesh's proposed slip and Ramvati's identity correction remain partial. In Chapter 79, two original images are found to depict different scenes and the allegation founded on a viral image against Janaki's group is explicitly withdrawn in writing; the editor's identity remains unknown, and Sarayu's livelihood is affected. In Chapter 80, the cloth belonging to Yusuf's particular customer is released; the disputed second bundle remains detained, while the separate dues of Rahim, Sakina, the fish market, and Lakhan advance only partly through procedure. The four outcomes share an ethical thread, not an identical legal or factual status.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, and Intertextuality

The ancient time of Lanka's Ashoka grove and royal residence occupies the beginnings of the first two chapters; the narrator then pursues an extensive contemporary branch in modern Videhapur. Chapter 77 returns to the Ashoka grove at the end; Chapter 78 closes on the modern school's record. Chapters 79–80 are substantially modern, multistranded narratives: a mythological equivalence cannot responsibly be imposed upon them. There are intertextual echoes between the narrative judgment of Sita, Trijata, and Mandodari and the archival rights exercised by modern women, not hereditary reincarnations or literal historical identities. Women's consent, distribution of household food, fear of war, and restricted state authority have particular significance in the ancient scenes; the precise social circumstances of modern labour and caste prejudice possess independent histories.

The expanded contemporaneity mingles old applications, unpaid wages, the unknown date when a viral clip was made, and proposed future hearings within the external sequence of one day from dawn to evening. Prolepsis here often takes the form of deferred information, though it would be wrong to call every wait an anticipation. The narrative voice is generally third-person; inward anxiety is available in varying measure through Sita, Mandodari, Sarayu, Yusuf, and others. Rather than a fixed single protagonist, there is shifting focalisation. This polycentric structure increases the reader's responsibility: however wide the narrator's presumed omniscience, not every narrated claim thereby becomes indubitable evidence.

Rasa, Evidence, Critical Achievement, and Counterargument

Karuna rasa emerges through Sita's unverified fears, Mandodari's dilemma over war, the humiliation of Sarayu's granddaughter, and Lata's unfinished search. Careless classification as vira or shanta rasa could diminish the complexity of women's endurance. From the perspective of dhvani in Indian poetics, a knot of thread, a bronze vessel, a wet rug, and the loom's two accounts suggest social memory and rights beyond their immediate meanings. Yet rasa is not independent proof in any administrative investigation: dramatic effect and a change in the actual state of affairs require separate measures. In narrative terms, the valid domains of evidence are distinguished in each pairing: hearing and direct perception, resemblance and identity, a receipt and a debt actually owed, a signature and informed consent. These arguments should not be mistaken for fabricated sutras from classical treatises or judicial rulings by the characters.

The ethical achievement of these four chapters is the social extension of the right to question: Trijata does not turn unconfirmed news into certainty; Mandodari sees the bodies of the deprived within an order; Janaki demands explicit repudiation of a degrading collective claim; and Yusuf requests an object-specific decision so an innocent length of cloth can be sold. Nevertheless, the critical counterargument remains substantial. The explicit grammar of documentation, consent, and forms returns in the speech of many characters in nearly the same way; the density of that repetition across the long novel may induce formal fatigue. Second, so many subordinate plots are presented successively within the span of one day that contingency can resemble an organised hearing. Third, disproportionate attention to administrative progress sometimes leaves characters' private disorientation and silence less visible. The conclusion, thus far, is neither that the novel fails nor that these are mere flaws. The long narrative must constantly negotiate between its ethical method and the diversity of narrative life. The next chapter, 81, 'The Child's Other Place', will test this unfinished search and dispute over evidence anew; no claim about its actual events is made here.

Chapter 81 — The Child's Other Place

The Bus-Stand Table: Refusing to Overread a Mystery

The chapter begins with a wet scrap of paper wedged beneath a leg of an uneven table belonging to a bus-stand tea seller. Half-erased words, 'next stop', catch Naira's eye, but she does not declare them a clue. Within the archival mystery developed thus far, this opening refusal is important: not every letter on a paper seen by the reader is a narrative puzzle. The tea seller has used the sheet to steady a table. A single object has both a commercial use and a possible attraction for investigation, but the obscurity of its contents does not establish its evidentiary value. The smell of raw milk, dust, and water collected beneath the bus wheels make this scene not merely symbolic but a concrete time and place of social movement.

Lata arrives with Kamli. The measurement of Mithun's blue kurta is still preserved in family memory, but the help desk's notice explicitly says that the contact location found in another child's case does not establish Mithun's whereabouts. The story stops before a familiar temptation of detective fiction. The same bus station, the overheard name of an intermediary, and a missing child invite the reader to find one source for them all; Naira interrupts the possible leap by saying, 'Finding a connection does not mean making an accusation.' This is not merely a moral maxim but a condition governing the narration of the subsequent investigation. The narrator does not yet disclose where Mithun is; the reader is not entitled to fill that blank merely because Lata wishes to do so.

A limitation of the opening's art also becomes apparent. Beside almost every significant document, a character immediately clarifies the limits of its evidence; the natural irresolution of mystery can at times sound like training in epistemology. Yet the paper at the bus stand, the tea seller's physical gesture, and Lata's memory of the blue kurta bring this theoretical density back to tangible objects and bodily distress. That is the successful initial rhythm of the chapter.

Gunja and Chameli: The Actual Event Register of Child Protection

Chameli comes looking for her twelve-year-old daughter Gunja. Gunja left home eleven days earlier after being promised an opportunity to work alongside her studies, but no written parental permission was obtained. Her location is traced to a sewing room; the formal process for a safe return home is still pending. Here lies the first actual change of events: a documented link concerning a particular child's situation is established, not merely rumour or inference. The dates in the room's admission register, two receipts from the bus stand, and Gunja's protected statement correspond. Her personal name was replaced by 'new assistant', a substitution that converts a human life into a category of production. Yet verification of the original signature remains outstanding; the individual part played by every potential offender has not been proved.

Lata asks, 'Has trafficking been proved?' The officer's answer differentiates the first confirmed sequence of transfers, obstruction of the return home, initiation of an inquiry, and the possibility of a criminal conviction in court at a future date. This response should not be elevated verbatim into a legal determination; it is the current condition of the inquiry at the level of a fictional character. Gunja's story is not Mithun's: Mithun's name does not appear on the two receipts. That absence does not prove that 'Mithun is nowhere'; it establishes only the limited fact that Mithun is not named on those two slips. Through such negative delimitation the word 'other' in the title becomes a defence of social individuality. Making the suffering of one child into an instrument for finding another would be a new form of human utilitarianism.

The flower stitched with blue thread in Gunja's school notebook, her desire to learn sewing, her resolve not to leave school, and her wish to meet a familiar teacher form a distinct character voice. Wanting to learn a trade and being confined for labour are not mutually contradictory assertions but separate questions of rights. The narrative does not criminalise every practice of labour; it treats freedom under the particular circumstances, education, and impediments to contacting home as decisive. Gunja's statement is not read aloud at the public table, and only an authorised portion of her letter is placed before her mother. Maternal love does not

erase a child's privacy. This is the feminist and child-rights achievement of the chapter.

Gunja alleges in her statement that a letter containing her home address was confiscated, a claim requiring investigation. The circumstances of two other adolescents found in the workshop are the subjects of separate inquiries. A proposal to turn them into one aggregate figure for 'rescue' is rejected. A counterargument deserves attention here: an administrative process necessary for children's protection may also cause delay. Chameli asks, 'When will she come home?' The answer is not immediate reunion. A review that celebrates only the success of confidentiality would make the mother's sleeplessness and the unresolved reality of the child's rehabilitation invisible. The text preserves this contradiction.

Contamination of Memory, the Tenancy Register, and the Status of Inference

The signboard of an alleged contact office has been removed from the eastern lane of the bus station. Traces of glue, a torn cash receipt, and blurred telephone digits remain. The landlord says the tenant left two days earlier; that testimony does not establish the tenant's liability or any direct link to the missing child. Naira makes an application for the original tenancy register for a lawful examination. Touching a chair, Lata asks whether Mithun might have sat there. Naira does not manufacture an answer, and Kamli objects to merging separate children's journeys on the basis of a similar chair. A potential climax of karuna rasa is held within the discipline of inference: grief is not licensed to create falsehood.

A bus employee first remembers Tuesday evening and then Wednesday evening. Having heard Gunja's account, he begins attaching its details to what he thinks he saw. A child-protection worker asks him to distinguish the facts originally perceived from details heard later. In contemporary cognitive narratology this is a scene of source contamination in memory: the present question enters the recollection of a past perception. The final classification of the statement is 'possible sighting, date uncertain'. This conclusion is not an officer's ignorance but maturity in classifying evidence. Theoretically, the same photograph or a similar name cannot provide a sufficient reason; qualifications concerning chronological sequence, place, and independent corroboration must be addressed.

During an authorised inspection the writing of a contact name in the rent register appears similar to that on Gunja's first receipt. Similar handwriting, however, does not conclusively prove an identical writer. Even so, confirmation that two original receipts were issued from the same contact location constitutes genuine progress. Evidentiary progress here means neither 'all suspects were found' nor 'the crime was solved', but that

a specific and usable investigative link has come into hand. In the language of inference, the reason offered for establishing the proposition—criminal participation by a named person—is weak if it consists solely of handwriting resemblance. Only original signatures, telephone records, and independent testimony could extend the permissible scope of the claim. The novel does not invent a court judgment at this point.

Wages Due, Durga's First Consignment, and Narrative Parallels

From the tenth textual unit, the story introduces the wages owed for repairs to a flood-relief shelter by Kedar Bauri, Phulwa, Jugal, and Shambhu. In a dispute in which wages were withheld by calling work during the flood 'service', work-time slips, oral evidence about agreed rates, and a missing register become important. Kedar refuses to treat standing with a wage document as if one were standing in a queue of offenders. The accountant proposes a small lump sum; the immediate need for medicine at Jugal's home makes the offer attractive. Phulwa asks whose dues the lump sum would cover, and by how much—and whether accepting it would extinguish the remaining claims. Eventually the joint claim is entered in the receipt register. The monetary offer is not treated as payment, and Jugal's separate request for an advance is recorded. The disagreement among characters is legitimate: private hardship must not be silenced by a collective proposal.

Durga Gangai herself sets the credit limit for her makhana-and-flattened-rice products. With Rukhsana's food collective she separately tests flavour, soaking time, and weight. Sale of three packets, the sale of half the first consignment, clear accounting of the advance, and the still-undecided flavour of the next consignment are concrete events in a small market; they do not mean Durga's trade has become an unqualified success. Reducing this commercial episode to another 'case of evidence', like the kidnapping investigation, would distort it. Food flavour, dried and damp packaging, buyers' tastes, and a woman's pricing decisions are the materials of genuine economic narration. An indistinct visual recollection by Rukhsana's adolescent co-worker also renews the warning against making unsupported claims in the child search. Three narrative currents meet at the bus station but do not become instruments for proving one another's criminal allegations.

A message from an unknown number says, 'You'll find him across the river; send the fare first.' It gives no name, time, or direct proof. Lata herself decides not to send money immediately and has the message preserved for official inquiry. The narrator does not turn her decision into a heroic legend; the bodily urge of an impatient mother searching for her son remains alongside Kamli's steady presence. Washing Mithun's plate at night and putting a blue cloth in the place of food are particular

expressions of karuna rasa. Waiting has not ended, but Lata frees herself slightly from the symbolic confinement of covering a plate with food every day. Gunja's protected care, the workers' registered claim, Durga's limited sales, and Mithun's continuing absence provide different outcomes for the principal subordinate plots.

Overall Examination of Narrative Arrangement and Artistic Limits

The chapter proceeds broadly from dawn through afternoon and evening into night. The centre shifts repeatedly among the bus station, lane, office, food stall, and home; focal consciousness expands from Lata's impatient questions to Chameli's rights, Kedar's accounting, and Durga's market intelligence. The third-person narrator has information organised more systematically than that of the characters, but delivers no omniscient conclusion concerning the offender or Mithun's location. Contrary to the indication of 'dual-temporal intertextuality', this chapter contains no independent epic scene: its distinct human timelines occur within the modern period. This evidence-based correction must be considered important.

The artistic strength lies in its combination of particular objects and unrealised outcomes: a school notebook, a wooden chair, partly erased digits, a plate, a wage slip, and the fragrance of flattened rice. Its limitation is that officers, Naira, Kedar, Durga, and the child-protection worker all speak almost the same evidence-disciplined formulas. The independent rhythms of the characters' social speech are sometimes absorbed into the voice of policy instruction. Yet Jugal's urgency about medicine, Chameli's sleeplessness, and Lata's ritual with the plate challenge this flattening. The chapter's narratological achievement is its refusal to make the certain suffering of one child into an answer to another child's uncertain future.

Chapter 82 — Maithili's Pages

The Old Chest and a Re-examination of Authorship

The chapter opens with a wooden chest kept in Maithili's drawer and pages preserved in two layers: one bearing Ishaan's original text in a neat hand, the other Maithili's revisions in blue ink. Fibres catching at the edges of the sheets, dry cloth, and air entering through the window tell the reader that the history of knowledge survives in fragile material objects. Sarita sets down the food without touching the pages, but offers practical advice about keeping the paper in a place with adequate light and ventilation so that it does not deteriorate. This first moment establishes the relationship between scholarship and domestic care. The material foundations of labour are present before the dispute over authorial credit begins.

Maithili does not immediately treat a letter with an incomplete date, fallen from the chest, as proof relating to the book. While acknowledging the precision of her own memory, she also marks the uncertainty of the date. Ishaan identifies the initial draft as his; Maithili places the revised copy before him and objects to treating her revisions as no more than marginal notes to that draft. The question in this scene is not who wrote every sentence of the book, but how credit is to be identified for a particular objection to the preliminary position and the consequent alteration of the argument. Maithili had objected to inferring an identical cause from an identical outcome. Such a revision is not merely a scribal correction: it is a conceptual reassessment of the relation between reason and probandum in inference. Nevertheless, the passage does not of itself constitute a final ruling on co-authorship.

Harimohan distinguishes the existence of handwritten pages from the question of participation in authorship. Handwriting, dates, the order of drafts, and direct textual evidence are all required; different ink colours do not conclusively prove different dates. Maithili does not conceal the weakness of the date supporting her own position. This self-scrutiny is a genuine point of development in her character: she refuses to overstep the limits of evidence even to defeat what she regards as an injustice. The existence of Ishaan's original argument remains secure, but the history of the revisions requires joint examination. It would be unfair to the reader to compress this dilemma into a public choice between "add the name" and "do not add the name."

Farid's Division of Time: The Social Value of Education

In the eighth passage, Farid arrives carrying an application for admission together with the shop's weekly accounts. This is not a subplot detached from the central authorship dispute, although neither is it a replica of that dispute. Farid divides his time between responsibilities in his father's family business of sorting and selling goods and his desire to attend evening classes and receive instruction in rhythm. He does not decide to flee the family's financial obligations; rather, he seeks to organise two hours of education as a civic right. The school application, shop ledger, teaching remuneration, and household dues constitute four separate accounts. Rights to labour and education are presented in tension, without a facile resolution.

His father's counter-question—"Out of whose profit will the additional worker's wages be paid?"—locates a difficult point of social realism. Farid shows the actual account of the days on which sales were made; he has not credited himself with earnings for a day on which he did not work. The blank space becomes visible evidence of reliability. His father signs an agreement about the allocation of time, not the school's final letter of admission. Initial agreement within the household and formal acceptance by the school are different stages. Thus, instead of the sentimental conclusion that Farid "has received an education," the novel displays the actual arithmetic of timetables, income, and the distribution of collective work. Savings from his instruction in rhythm become a means of buying books; the household's financial obligations remain.

Categories of Credit: Original Argument, Question, Example, and Copying

Harimohan first establishes three categories: the original argument, proposed revision, and editing or transcription. Ishaan claims authorship of his original exposition. After Maithili's questions, the form of the example changed, and the two discussed certain new conclusions. This acknowledgment opens the way to establishing participation in the revisions, but determining the extent of co-authorship requires examination of particular pages. Maithili requests preliminary public acknowledgment, with final certification to come later; Ishaan agrees that the history of the revisions should be recorded in writing. The actual change in the course of events lies less in accusation and counter-accusation than in the development of a documentary process.

At one point Maithili refrains from raising private birth records with Naira. She also prevents a possible report about Kabir's birth and Sarita's

original sheet containing twenty-seven names from being turned into examples in the authorship dispute. This delicate ethical boundary matters. Private biography, public credit for literary revision, and an unresolved search for a child belong to three different kinds of document. Pressure to disclose private information in support of revision could become an authoritarian conviction that everything is permissible "for the sake of truth." While asserting her own rights, Maithili protects other people's private records. Feminist narratology here means more than adding a woman's name; it means recognising the right to decide at the boundary between privacy and public creation.

A small register is prepared recording the external marks on the original pages, the number of selected copies, their place of custody, the inspector, and permission to copy them. Maithili's handwritten revisions have been presented, and the examination of her participation continues: this is the actual institutional achievement. No order has yet been made to print another name on the published book. Criticism must preserve this precise state of affairs. The narrative does not turn a brief written acknowledgment into a substitute for full justice. Ishaan is prepared to make the pages available for public scrutiny; Maithili asks for an examination of their historical responsibility. Together, these positions generate a dynamic tension.

Temporal Organisation, Focalisation, and the Unfinished Hearing

The chapter extends from opening the chest at dawn to gathering the pages at night. Through recollection, the narrative briefly returns to the time of the earlier manuscript; it does not present a separate Mahabharata-era temporal strand. Different inks, the incomplete date, and the material differences between printed editions are objects of evidence concerning the past, not directly dramatised scenes from the past. "Reconstruction of the past through a present investigation" is more accurate here than "dual temporality." Focalisation shifts from Maithili's desire to read the pages to Ishaan's discomfort, Farid's economic responsibilities, and Sarita's control over her time. The narrator avoids claiming unrestricted access to everyone's inner thoughts: at the end, Maithili cannot know whether Sarita feels relieved by her response.

Artistically, the drawer, ink, towel, fragile pages on the table, and sounds of dishes and bread-making give knowledge a bodily location. The final scene is particularly important: Maithili offers to wash the dishes the following morning, and Sarita replies that she will show her some pages then. The claim to make one's own pages public is thus linked to an ethical obligation to hear about another person's labour. This emotional change is more convincing than a verbose apology. A limitation is that every

character seems in turn to classify matters as "original text, revision, or transcription"; the unscripted intensity of real domestic disagreement may thereby be diminished. Yet the classification is the central object of investigation here, not a distant illustrative device, and the repetition therefore has substantial contextual justification.

Chapter 83 — Sarita's Labour

The Hearth and the Blue Notebook: A Double Account of Time

The chapter begins with a half-burned piece of coal rolling from Sarita's hearth and the blue notebook rescued from it. The first page records rice, oil, and lentils; on the seventh, prose composed of questions and answers abruptly appears. Domestic subsistence and philosophical study are present in the handwriting of the same person. Their coexistence on the same paper does not establish that both kinds of labour amount to identical forms of authorship. Sarita first removes the rice from the fire, washes her hands, and only then opens the notebook. The material sequence matters. Instead of making kitchen work disappear under the label of "assistance to knowledge," the chapter shows its particular demands on the body and on time. Maithili takes hold of a lid while avoiding the hot steam; a new relationship around labour develops through unforced laughter.

On the seventh page, "cause" has subsequently been replaced by "reason" (hetu). Other pages are needed to establish whose explanation prompted the change. Sarita remembers the season of the paddy harvest, but does not turn the memory of a season into a definite date on paper. Drying damp pages, making replacement copies, and asking about the meanings of characters before writing them are actual acts of transcription. Some letters she understood and corrected herself; about others she asked Maithili or Ishaan. This candid account of mixed sources distinguishes the "hand that wrote" from the "originator of the idea." Sarita is not depicted as the conventionally self-sacrificing housewife. She is a discerning participant who defines the nature of her work, its date, and the limits of the credit it merits.

The printed acknowledgment of "assistance from the household" cannot encompass Sarita's days, the ingredients for meals, her nighttime copying, and the sources of examples. Yet she does not demand comprehensive authorship of the book. Her insistence—"A name matters, but listen to the work first"—becomes a central critical test of the method of parallel history. Merely adding an omitted name is insufficient. One must examine what the person did, at whose request, for how long, and for what payment. Here the novel avoids the superficial historiographical practice of inserting a "representative" name for a Dalit, a woman, or a worker as though that could encompass the totality of their experience.

Three Kinds of Sources and Three Kinds of Labour

Sarita distinguishes three examples: measuring water in a pond, weighing goods in a warehouse, and settling dues at a river landing. She witnessed the first directly, heard about the second from Rukhsana, and copied the third from a source whose original she had not seen. In the earlier dispute about teaching, they had all been absorbed into the text as ordinary "practices of the people." Sarita had objected to that equivalence, but her question found no place in the book. Maithili acknowledges that she had dismissed the question of sources with the immediate assurance that the example "would do." Her self-criticism is ethically connected to her demand for authorial recognition. There can be no justice in securing acknowledgment for one woman at the cost of leaving another woman's labour unnamed.

Two sacks of equal weight may have different material histories: one has been soaked, the other remains dry. Sarita's direct experience of the market prompts conditional thinking about an inferential reason. Her observation, however, does not itself establish that she wrote the book's entire revised theory. The origin of the question, the language of the formulation, and the textual sequence of the published edition require separate examination. This distinction puts narrative reasoning to meaningful social use: an identical outcome does not warrant a necessary inference to the same cause until alternative causes have been excluded. The philosophical plot succeeds here because direct knowledge gained through labour conventionally placed "below" the family's scholarship exposes a defect in the teacher's formula.

Before Harimohan, Sarita lays out three classes of document: pages of copying, an expenditure record for food and clothing, and a list of the sources of examples. Copying and writing, expense and labour, and experience and knowledge constitute distinct contributions. The working register accordingly acquires separate fields for days spent cooking, known pages copied, suggestions for revision, sources of examples, and permission to inspect. Two days of voluntarily shared meals are distinguished from three days of requested transcription. This is an ethical accounting of time: "free of charge" does not have the same meaning for every task. Sarita stops an offer of immediate unitemised payment because it could produce the false story that the entire obligation had been settled. Rights to remuneration and rights concerning the provenance of an argument are not a single commodity to be bargained over.

Lakshmi Jhangar's Independent Right over the Archive

In the eighth passage, Lakshmi Jhangar arrives with a copy of a labour agreement. She states plainly that no photograph will be taken of private pages; she wants a copy of the application, not a narrative of her grandfather's entire life. The old contract separately records the season, accommodation, and an advance of grain. The personally authorised signature for the sum described as a "family debt" is unclear. The presence of an ancestor's name on one page and the word "family" on another does not automatically establish that the same individual owes the debt. Lakshmi refuses to enter the amount as "proven outstanding dues" without checking the original register. Such precision is methodologically fundamental to writing a parallel history of hereditary labour: collective identity cannot erase individual consent, the duration of a contract, or the specific terms of payment.

Maithili asks to use Lakshmi's copy as an example in her philosophical discussion; Lakshmi refuses. "My grandfather's wages are not an example for your philosophy." This brief rebuttal exposes the power relation between philosophical narrative and social reality. A marginalised person is not merely a "mine of examples," but someone entitled to decide how evidence is used. Maithili admits the carelessness of her question and limits her request to learning the general method. Her development as a character is directly visible in her willingness to hear another person's rights. Lakshmi does not send the original papers by post; she verifies the office's published telephone number and keeps the necessary copies and a future inspection appointment separate. The novel makes no claim that submitting the application has resulted in the worker receiving payment. The economic struggle remains unresolved.

This interwoven narrative also has a possible limitation. The dispute about Maithili's writing, Sarita's transcription, and the wages owed to Lakshmi's ancestors are all highly significant, yet the characters reject the misuse of personal examples with nearly identical methodological clarity. Inequality of power, fear, urgency, and humiliation can become enclosed within well-ordered arguments. Even so, Lakshmi's demand for time rather than travel expenses, and Sarita's matching of the appointment with the hours of her own sewing work, make visible the economic cost of producing knowledge.

Rereading Silence and the Educated Woman's Self-Criticism

At an earlier public reading of the acknowledgment, Maithili had spoken of "help from the people of the household." Sarita had been sitting in a back row and had not objected. Maithili accepts her share of

responsibility for that silence. Sarita explains that she had needed to sit down and calculate the cost of the food, and that her power to inconvenience those on the platform was not equal to theirs. Here a limiting condition is exposed in the argument that equates "silence" with "consent." Failing to speak in conditions of unequal power is not sufficient evidence of agreement. But Sarita also rejects the suggestion that she had formally demanded credit at the time. It would be equally wrong to invent a retrospective story of resistance. Harimohan records the two independent memories of the same occasion separately. For contemporary feminist narratology, this is a particularly subtle moment: the woman who speaks in the present does not license a redemptive rewriting of what she said in the past.

Ishaan recognises four pages copied by Sarita, but does not pull the notebook towards himself; he asks about the limits of permission. The earlier teacher-centred authority of knowledge begins to crack not through theatrical surrender but through a small change of conduct. Naira's original sheet containing twenty-seven names remains separately protected, and the file concerning the search for Mithun is not mixed with these records. After the meal, Maithili makes an unsuccessful attempt to roll out a round roti. Its "map," Sarita jokes, is not evidence of ownership of land. This humour brings living dramatic energy to the chapter's densely classified dialogue. The differences among original argument, labour rights, and direct experience are reconnected to hunger, taste, and the body.

Outcome: A Public Register of Labour, Not the Final Distribution of Credit

At the close of the chapter, Sarita's blue notebook returns to its secure box. Maithili offers to prepare the roti next time, but Sarita asks whether anyone has thought to ask what she herself likes to eat. This question of "preference" translates the chapter's entire inquiry into consent into ordinary domestic terms. The three days of copying have not yet been paid for in full; final credit for the sources of examples has not been decided; and Maithili's claim about her handwritten pages is proceeding through a separate process. To describe the outcome as "Sarita declared a co-author" or "Ishaan accepted everything" would contradict the original text.

The chapter's narrated time runs from morning to night in a single day, but memories of an earlier paddy season, pages soaked in a flood, and a previous meeting return within it. The past is not shown to the reader as a directly enacted scene; it is reconstructed through memory, pages, and independent statements. Sarita's focal consciousness is more active here

than before. She is not merely a figure of suffering but someone who establishes categories of evidence and determines the conditions on which she gives her time. The artistic achievement lies in deriving a critique of authority over knowledge from scenes of domestic work. Its limitation lies in the recurrent registers, categories, and cautions. Yet this repetition is repeatedly interrupted by Sarita's laughter, boiling water, and the fatigue of labour.

Chapter 84 — The Teacher's Acknowledgment

Authority over the Original Proposition and Historical Responsibility for Revision

The chapter opens with a blue stain on Ishaan's finger from the book's binding. Whether the ink spread during binding or was transferred later from a wet hand remains uncertain. Parallel to this ambiguous mark stand three bundles: Ishaan's original handwritten exposition, two printed editions, and a notice drafted in response to students' questions. The opening question about the colour repeats the evidentiary discipline of the preceding chapters, but this time Ishaan is examining the history of his own name. The proposition, reason, and example in the original argument are in his hand; Maithili's marginal question—"Why infer one cause from the same sign?"—played a role in the later revision. He does not disown his original contribution, but neither does he allow the history of revision to end with a single name.

Harimohan makes it clear that this review at the school is not a judicial verdict. The handwriting of the original argument, Maithili's question, and the differences between printed editions are separate items of evidence. Ishaan recalls the earlier debate with the students, but accepts responsibility for the absence of a complete history of the revisions from the publication page. This statement carries the distinctive suggestiveness of Drona Parva. Being a teacher, and having originated the initial argument, does not annul a pupil's or domestic colleague's right to receive credit for revisions; equally, acknowledging the teacher's fault does not make every one of his propositions false. The earlier implication in the second edition that equal weight entails an identical source has been revised, but the exact date of revision cannot be determined from the year of publication. The uncertainty restrains both creator and critic from an impatient final verdict.

Sarita arrives for a limited period, leaving aside her first customer's sewing. She distinguishes between time spent listening and taking her pages merely to protect someone else's book. Ishaan admits the error of merging copying, cooking, and work on the sources into an indistinct expression of thanks for "household assistance." Sarita, however, asks for a written description rather than repentance alone. Harimohan classifies original composition, revision, transcription, directly witnessed examples, second-hand examples, and the organisation of materials into separate fields. This classification is not a mechanical imitation of classical epistemology, but a material way of regulating public credit and wages separately.

Mangari's Wages: A Social Test of the Teacher's Reasoning

In the eleventh passage, Mangari arrives with a list of amounts due to seven workers from the closed Gorait factory. A new gate has blocked the old route to their workplace. Prema, Bholu, Saroj, and the others have worked for different periods; the seventh member is absent because of illness. Mangari is a representative, not the owner of everyone else's claim. Each worker's consent to making copies is recorded separately. This is a living form of collective leadership by a woman: representation does not extinguish the independent claims of the represented workers. Histories of labour need both collective organisation and individual identity.

A receipt marked "group payment" leaves the recipient's bank-account field blank. A guard repeats what he has heard—that the owner has paid everyone in full—but offers no proof. Harimohan regards only the existence of the written receipt as established; actual payment and the authority of its source require separate verification. Ishaan explains the distinction among direct perception, testimony, and analogy, but Mangari stops him: he may explain the distinction, she says, but he cannot set the price of her labour. Her interruption expresses the limit of philosophy's social jurisdiction. A teacher can teach the evaluation of evidence; practical experience of livelihood and decisions about remuneration belong to the workers concerned. Ishaan's silence is not the silence produced by institutional pressure in Chapter 16, but an exercise in accepting the limits of his knowledge.

Mangari divides the application into three parts: arrears accruing until the factory closed; cleaning and transport performed after closure; and the cost of protective equipment bought by the workers themselves. The office issues receipt numbers for two applications and requires a separate procedure for the third. The absent worker's claim is not included without permission. A receipt for gloves proves that the item was bought, not that the owner ordered its purchase. The struggle is not over: the wages have not been received, the new gate remains closed, and the factory has not reopened. But the outstanding claims now enter a public register of accountability. The real eventfulness of this passage is not confined to the receipt number. Seven different work histories, consent from an absent member, and a new category for safety expenses change the social state of affairs within the plot.

A Public Statement: The Limited Achievement of Admitting Error

Maithili recognises that her own list of contributions is incomplete. Ishaan writes at once that Maithili raised the question concerning the revised example, that the original argument was his, and that comparison

of the pages is continuing. Harimohan refuses to call this public acknowledgment a final allocation of credit. Ishaan recognises the problem of uncredited household labour as an appropriation of recognition, but warns against turning Sarita into an unwilling co-author as a decorative tribute. Sarita keeps three questions separate: earned payment, time lost, and the provenance of examples she witnessed directly. The substance of this changed dialogue is that admitting wrongdoing is necessary, but the form of redress cannot be decided without the consent of the person affected.

Uday worries that the teacher's public admission of error may weaken the students' trust. Ishaan states plainly that a defect in the teacher's conduct does not automatically invalidate a principle of inference, while knowledge of a valid principle does not automatically excuse the teacher's conduct. The validity of knowledge and the ethics of the knower require separate examinations. This critical distinction is a major example of the novel's philosophical vitality. The purpose is not to destroy recognition of philosophical authority, but to prevent it from becoming unchallengeable personal power. At this point the ethical relevance of Indian Nyaya reasoning emerges; the novel's statement, however, must not be presented as a verbatim maxim from the Tattvacintamani or the Nyayakusumanjali.

Ishaan pins a preliminary letter to the noticeboard. He does not remove his own name; he identifies Maithili's contribution, records Sarita's labour separately, and announces a period for objections and a later opportunity to inspect the sources. A student asks permission to examine the differences between pages. But a new edition of the printed book has not appeared, no final determination of joint authorship has been made, and the money due has not been paid. The character's formulation—"Acknowledgment in words, payment of dues, and justice in authorship are separate stages"—defines the chapter's outcome without exaggeration. It would be inappropriate to end by celebrating the moral triumph of a revered teacher. Public self-examination is preliminary; institutional reform depends on procedure.

The Lesson after the Meal: Scene Duration and the Limits of Emotional Resolution

In the evening class, the example of equal weights of wet and dry grain recurs. Since its actual source in lived experience remains under investigation, Ishaan explicitly presents it in teaching as a hypothetical test case. This is not confined to the page-by-page examination of authorship: it changes the method of teaching. Farid asks whether an example can be used when the person who originally experienced it is absent. The answer

clearly separates a hypothetical test from an event directly observed. Ethical acknowledgment of sources is being turned into a practical rule of teaching. The story has not yet shown how extensively the students will put this change into practice later; its consequences must therefore be considered provisional.

In the household kitchen, Maithili rolls out rotis while Ishaan brings water at Sarita's direction. These small tasks do not settle earlier dues, but they reveal the limitations of pronouncing on the ethics of labour without experiencing bodily work. Sarita has the vague phrase "invaluable assistance" replaced by specific references to three days of copying, the provision of meals, and the sources of examples. "Invaluable" sounds like praise for the value of labour, but can in practice erase the price that is owed. This irony in the language of value exposes violence concealed within appreciative vocabulary. Ishaan revises the sentence; the actual amount payable and the final proof regarding sources remain unsettled.

In the final scene, Ishaan puts the original register into a bag. The argument on the first page is his; historical responsibility for the revision on the second is subject to joint scrutiny, and the anonymous acknowledgment needs to be read again. The lamp goes out, but a second copy of the letter is left where it will be visible in the morning light. The return of material objects is beautifully achieved: the intertext of lamp and paper from Chapter 33 becomes, in Chapter 84, the open light of the teacher's acknowledgment. Nevertheless, there is a risk of didactic explicitness: almost every exchange seems to announce a carefully calibrated conclusion. The damp earth on Mangari's towel, Sarita's box of needles, and a student's uncomfortable question restore life to the characters. Drona Parva closes not with a conch blast of victory, but with the durable time required for public questioning.

Drona Parva / Sundara Kanda: Overall Critical Assessment of Chapters 73–84

Structure: From the Journey of Identification to the Teacher's Acknowledgment

The twelve chapters of Drona Parva fall into three narrative sequences. Chapters 73–76 begin the question of ownership of sources through the landing at Simatirtha, Drona's due, the misleading resemblance of the digit "7," and Ekalavya's right to learn. Chapters 77–80 expose the incompleteness of public knowledge through Trijata's message based on what she has heard, Mandodari's distribution ledger, the false digital resemblance of faces, and Yusuf's weaver's accounts. In the final sequence, Chapters 81–84, Gunja's child-labour case, Maithili's handwritten revisions, Sarita's time spent working, and Ishaan's public acknowledgment give these questions an institutional form for making decisions. This is not a story in which the crime is solved or the teacher "has reformed completely"; it is a discipline of differentiating evidence and recognising the limits of authority.

Chapters 81–84 have respectively 28, 28, 27, and 27 non-empty original passages, giving a total of 110. Estimates of word-units in the preceding narrative are respectively 2,652, 2,735, 2,562, and 2,618. These counts are based on a particular Unicode method and are not equivalent to ordinary whitespace-delimited word counts. The narrative tag "dual-temporal intertext" could not be verified as it stood for Chapter 81; these final four chapters contain no independent scene from the ancient epic world. Epic consciousness instead operates through memories of Drona and Ekalavya from the earlier portion of the parva and through reconsideration of the teacher–student relationship. This editorial fact prevents the mistaken critical method that assumes "same title equals same scenic representation."

Mahabharata–Ramayana Resonance and Dramatic Opposition

Drona's guru-dakshina, Ekalavya's independent learning, and the modern Ishaan's public self-criticism constitute a suggestive constellation. The structural name Drona Parva raises questions about the rights involved in modern education, but it would be a mistake to regard Ishaan as Drona "reborn." The material circumstances of Drona's personal pride, Ekalavya's bodily loss, and Ishaan's dispute over authorial credit are different. Their connection is one of ethical counterargument: reverence for a teacher cannot replace the independent testing of knowledge or the

participation of pupils. The relation to the name Sundara Kanda lies in the earlier narrative thread of messengers, evidence, and crossing boundaries. A distinct Lanka scene involving Trijata and Sita is directly present in Chapter 77, whereas that temporal strand is absent from Chapters 81–84. The seven-kanda map of the Ramayana is thus a structural paratext, not an obligation to stage a corresponding scene in every chapter.

In terms of Indian poetics, karuna rasa takes different forms in the incomplete homecoming of Lata, Chameli, and Gunja, in Sarita's invisible labour, and in Mangari's unpaid wages. Brief moments of humour in the roti-making scene, the "map" made of dough, and the hot lid that burns Maithili's fingers interrupt the didactic quality of the discourse about knowledge. At the level of dhvani, a blank space in a page is not merely an absence; it suggests deferred decisions and the time in which rights remain suspended. Nevertheless, it would be a mistake to call all these experiences "one and the same suggestion of pathos": Gunja's fear, Farid's desire for education, and Ishaan's hesitation are distinct experiences.

Epistemological Contributions and Their Limits

The principal epistemic achievement of the parva is the threefold distinction among object, meaning, and authority. A signed slip exists, but the authenticity and purpose of its signature require examination. Words have appeared on a school noticeboard, but that does not establish the truth of a public accusation. Ishaan's name is printed in a philosophical book, but his name alone does not reveal whose question caused an example to change. A receipt for group payment exists, but it does not prove that every worker actually received the amount due. Distinctions inspired by narratology and epistemology—vyapti, upadhi, perception, testimony, and inference—here become an artistic critique of social power. It would be inappropriate to claim that the philosophical procedures of the original treatises have simply been transposed unchanged; the narrative uses their principles in response to its own modern questions.

A limitation of the method is that many different characters almost always articulate evidentiary refinements in clear and explicit language. Officials, children, workers, teachers, and traders do not speak with such uniformity in actual life. The repetition has a double effect: it protects the reader from confusing speculation with certainty, but it can also flatten the distinctions among social voices and the sounds of psychological inconsistency. Serious criticism must examine this defect, not praise it away as a "purely logical style." When the novel shows Lata's plate, Gunja's

school notebook, Durga's dried ginger, Maithili's hot lid, and Mangari's torn glove, its language is immersed once more in human experience.

Parallel History: Names for Labour and the Price of Time

From the standpoint of Videha parallel history, this parva places at the centre of the narrative not simply royal power or the thoughts of famous men, but the less frequently narrated means of living: boatmen, children, tailors, weavers, office copyists, laundry workers, relief builders, itinerant teachers, and domestic cooks. A list of occupations alone, however, does not prove social inclusion. The decisive questions are: How is Jugal's right to an immediate advance recorded separately? How does Gunja retain authority over her private statement? Under what constraints does Maithili make her page-by-page revisions public? Does Sarita demand an accounting of actual work time in place of an anonymous acknowledgment that her contribution was "invaluable"? How does Mangari represent seven workers without dissolving all their names into one collective claim? The novel's parallel history becomes operative through these questions.

The extended social reality of the parva consists in its refusal to confuse an office receipt number with a solution, safe care with a return home, private admission with the public allocation of credit, or the proposal of an initial advance with payment. The narrative preserves the long duration of institutional processes in an uncomfortable form. Nevertheless, a succession of numerous unfinished hearings across twelve chapters may exhaust the reader's sense of forward movement. It would also be wrong, when criticising the dramatic intensity, to dismiss workers' prolonged waiting as "unnecessary elaboration." The two levels must be kept distinct.

Conclusion: Not an Ethical Ending, but the Beginning of Accountability

The preliminary letter that Ishaan posts on the noticeboard in Chapter 84 provides Drona Parva with a measured ending. He does not withdraw his claim to the original composition. He acknowledges Maithili's specific question by name, publicly separates Sarita's work of copying, cooking, and supplying sources, and leaves the remaining decisions open to examination. Alongside this limited acknowledgment, Gunja's return home, the search for Mithun, Jugal's advance, Mangari's wages, and the final determination of Maithili's credit all remain unresolved. The true measure of epic amplitude here is not the scale of victory but the unfinished inventory of responsibility. The next Karna Parva may develop questions of birth, identity, and entitlement upon this incomplete world

of evidence inherited from Drona Parva. That is a possible path of reading; its specific outcome must not be asserted without examination of the following chapters themselves.

Chapter 85 — Radha's Labour

Radha's Veranda: A Site of Labour, a Prehistory of the Name

The chapter opens with Radha's hands in the settlement outside Hastinapura. She cuts, dries and measures damp cloth for binding the chariot wheel. The scene does not begin with Karna's celebrated valour or the concealment of his birth. Instead, the narrator places a woman's measuring, thread, time and livelihood at the origin of a male epic figure. Adhiratha's chariot had jolted along a damaged road the previous day. Unless the binding holds, the horses will have to work harder and the fare will be lost. The chariot is certainly a symbol here, but it is first a material instrument of transport. Before the question "Who is Karna by birth?" the narrative establishes its actual point of entry: "Whose labour sustains Karna's household?"

Radha treats Karna's hand, cut by the bowstring. Her questions concern technique, not caste prohibition. Karna does not wish to repeat a humiliating remark from the market before his mother, yet Radha understands the emotional meaning of his silence. Focalisation shifts from outward activity towards Karna's suppressed feelings; the narrator does not reveal his whole future, only his immediately wounded self-respect. Adhiratha prevents him from lifting a hot metal rim: the possibilities held in Karna's hands are greater than the chariot that provides their living. Thus both caregivers act to protect the child's body and future autonomy. In modern discussions, the value of caregiving is not simply a substitute for birth, but an independent relationship in its own right. The novel embodies that fine distinction in household activity.

The Household Ledger: The Economics of Unpaid Women's Labour

Adhiratha has received only half his wages. Radha sold her share of grain to buy materials for the chariot; she wants the costs of barley, oil and thread recorded separately. This is not merely a dialogue about self-respect but the institution of an account. An economic contribution might disappear under ordinary household expenses or the "help" a wife gives. Radha distinguishes the item, its source and its beneficiary. The experience of Dhairi, an elderly seamstress, leads to a change in the first measurement of the binding. Radha describes the revision not as proof that the first measure was false, but as the result of new, changing information. Dhairi receives her payment immediately: friendship does not cancel a worker's right to wages. She retains the right to take measurements by her own judgment until the final scene. This internal recurrence connects the chapter's opening and ending through the craftswoman's authority to decide.

A messenger summons Adhiratha for royal transport but specifies no payment for waiting, meals or materials. Radha does not announce that a contract has been settled; she has those invisible costs entered as questions. Epic kingship may draw upon labour, but it has no self-evident entitlement to appropriate a worker's time. Read through the Videha parallel-history perspective, the chariot behind the historical "hero" makes visible its manufacture, animal feed, thread, a woman's seed grain and casual wages. One caution is indispensable, however: the novel depicts Radha keeping an expense account; it does not provide an authenticated historical ledger of ancient Hastinapura's economy. This is imaginative reconstruction, not economic history verified from an archive.

The Question of Birth: The Coexistence of Two Truths

Karna asks how much Radha knows of the story of his birth. Her answer rests on her experience of the first day she cared for him; she does not invent the unknown life preceding it. This is an ethically forceful scene. Acknowledging the incompleteness of his prehistory does not diminish the truth of Radha's care; nor can the intensity of care replace an unknown biological fact. In narratological terms, direct experience of upbringing supplies evidence about an object different from information about birth. A reason advanced for one proposition cannot establish another proposition in full. Rather than displaying technical philosophical terminology at length, the novel concentrates this discrimination in a mother's measured answer.

The fragment of an unfinished folk song is the human counterpoint to this evidentiary discipline. Radha forgets its remaining line; Dhairi recalls another version. Neither considers it necessary to argue for a single authentic text. Yet this openness must not be taken as permission to alter a person's birth record at will. Variants of a folk song and documents concerning individual rights belong to different genres. The softened rhythm is useful narratively: amid repeated questions and answers, shared laughter, hunger and the hearth prevent the characters from becoming mere spokespeople for theories of justice.

Videhapur, 2039: Three Distinct Struggles Against a Consolidated Liability

In its ninth segment the narration shifts from the ancient veranda to a grain warehouse in Videhapur in 2039. This marked transition of time and place is concrete evidence of a dual-temporal narrative, not a mere echo of epic names. Kiran Raut's tenancy paper names the proprietor, yet seed debt and transportation charges have been added to her share. Her daughter Rekha prepares three columns but refuses to treat a calculation written by

her own hand as an authorised signature. Her father stops the child from being made a witness to an unknown debt. Knowledge of arithmetic and the authority to acknowledge a liability are separate here. A weighing slip states the weight delivered, not the legitimacy of a sharecropping division or seed debt. The disputed deduction is placed in a separate envelope, allowing the undisputed sacks to be collected. No debt has been waived, but the immediate achievement is to prevent the grain from spoiling.

Ratan Bhuiyan's contract slip prints wages and the contractor's tools together; a clerk claims that the recurrence of a name proves a single debt. Ratan distinguishes the hammer he bought himself from the contractor's spade. He requests the original acknowledgment; the debt is not forgiven. At Lakshmi Kathbaniya's shop, "jointly liable for the committee loan" has been added below the receipt for goods sold. She separates membership, supply and indebtedness into three categories. These three people are not representatives of an undifferentiated collective called "the oppressed"; each enters the narrative with distinct questions of money, tools, family land and ownership of sales. Kabir does not disclose Mangri's individual labour application without permission in his assistance room, and suggests separate administrative procedures for each. Social justice thus becomes a practice of evidence and representation, not merely a word.

Kabir's Memory: The Ethical Continuity of Care

In the evening Kabir asks Sarita whether a life becomes less real when its history of caregiving survives in fewer documents. Sarita refuses to construct a simple opposition between memory and paper. Memory grows from material experience—a wet schoolbag, a dried notebook, the smell of grain—but its dates and agents may still be questioned. She reassures Kabir that correcting a memory does not reduce affection. Kabir cannot acquire, merely by wishing it, the right to disclose in public a possible account of Subhadra's birth or the privacy of the woman who raised her. Karna's question to Radha and Kabir's question to Sarita have both similarities and differences: two sons seek unknown contexts of birth, but their familial situations, languages and kinds of records differ. One character is not the reincarnation of the other.

The twenty-third through twenty-fifth segments return to Hastinapura: the wheel binding is checked, the price of Radha's barley is entered in the household account, and Karna prepares to practise after eating. The twenty-sixth and twenty-seventh show three separate stages reached by the modern documents and the blank space for Kabir's name. The transition between these scenes does not make one temporal strand evidence for the other; it asks the reader to make a comparative judgment. Kabir does not fill the empty space himself at the end. This postponement is the artistic

answer offered at the opening of Karna Parva: more important than waiting for the solution to an unknown birth is respect for the life of care that is independently established.

Critical Assessment: Strengths and Narrative Limits

The chapter's finest achievement is to make labour measurable work rather than a sentimental metaphor. Dhairi's sewing, Radha's grain, Kiran's weighing, Ratan's tools, Lakshmi's supply and Kabir's household memories give meaning to different social relations. Focalisation moves from Radha to Karna, Kiran to Rekha, Ratan to Lakshmi and Kabir to Sarita, without the narrator omnisciently declaring anyone's unknown private facts. A limitation of the narrative arrangement is that many characters repeat explicit cautions such as "two documents are not one" or "no decision without the original." The swift arrival of a separate envelope or new application as the response to several disputes can make life's disorder seem excessively orderly. Nevertheless, outstanding claims remain unresolved after the central events, mitigating the fault of an easy moral victory. Taken together, the symmetry between Radha's veranda and Kabir's blank page offers a powerful opening to Karna Parva's central question.

Chapter 86 — The Original Page

The Brass Box: The Right to See, the Right to Keep

The chapter begins with old thread, dried flowers and papers in Sarita's brass box. Their fragile material condition matters: a page's originality consists not merely in its list of names but in its folds, handwriting, revisions and history of custody by its author. Naira turns off her telephone; Sarita unfolds the first two layers, leaving the last fold covered. Consent to inspect an original is not permission to transfer it; inspection is not publication; and a mother's silence is not an absence of information but a chosen boundary. In that sense, the initial prohibition is itself an important event: Naira will gain some genuine knowledge, but not unlimited authority.

The twenty-six names on the two exposed folds agree numerically with the earlier copy. One letter in the third line had been rendered more definitely in the copy; Naira adds a question mark rather than inventing a complete name. Sarita rejects the presumption of a single explanation for four names written in different ink. One belongs to an application for correction, another to a family name that entered the wrong page; the remaining two arose in different circumstances. Different ink is observable, but its date or cause is not self-evident. Naira's crossing out of a line containing an earlier conjecture directly marks her development as a self-critical character. Just as revising received information is part of the pursuit of truth in archival research, the narrative makes it an opportunity to examine one's intentions rather than an inexpensive dramatic revelation of criminal intrigue.

An old receipt of submission carries a time and a serial number, not a hearing's decision. Agreement between its sequence and the list of names does not establish that a petition was accepted. Sarita says that she wrote the names not to catch criminals but to account for the work of people stranded in an unfinished process. That purpose prevents the list from being converted into an official "register of suspects." The twenty-seventh entry within the fold remains undisclosed to the end. The title's number makes the reader impatient, but the plot measures that impatience against the rights of the woman who owns the page.

Original, Copy and Office: Three Distinct Chains of Provenance

The original handwritten by Sarita remains at home; Naira's transcription is a partial representation of it; the circulating sealed office copy is a product of a separate registration process. Sarita permits Naira to record the twenty-six exposed names, the state of the folds, the inspection date and

the covered portion, but not to remove the original from its box. To write that "the original was obtained and entirely opened" would contradict the text. Naira learns three things: a transcription error involving one letter, a mistaken generalisation about the four names written in different ink, and the restricted nature of her consent to inspect the original. An object's material existence, its author's statement, a copy's inaccuracy and an office entry are different evidentiary sources. The narratological distinction of paksha, hetu and sadhya is aptly applied here: seeing "this letter is different" cannot establish "this person is a criminal"; the supposed universal association of identical ink or seals with a particular conclusion is unproved.

One distinctive achievement of the novel is that neither collaborator overrules the other's rights while inspecting the copy. Naira records the incompleteness of the handwritten transcription; Sarita admits that she does not know when she made an earlier correction. This admission counters the tendency to treat an archival original as absolutely free from error. The original carries a correction by its author's hand, but the question of its date remains open. Criticism must distinguish the authenticity of a source from the truthfulness or accuracy of its statements: learning who wrote something still leaves the questions of when and why it was written.

The Great Pond: Women's Fishing Rights and Movement

From the fifth to the thirteenth segment, the accounts of Ramani Bind, Tara Mallick, Urmila, Aditi and Renu Gondhi develop. Ramani brings a letter from her maternal home bearing the name "Gangi," but herself says that it documents her maternal family's life, not a map establishing a river boundary. Renu's old letter mentioning the place-name "Dhauri" has a similarly limited status: it records the memory of a name, not the river's mapped course. These two instances reward reading through the Videha parallel-history perspective. Letters, women's oral memories and naming practices beyond the main revenue register open historical questions; honouring local memory, however, does not render it infallible geography.

Tara measures mud depth at three places in the pond; Aditi documents observations at those points, not an average depth for the entire pond. A contractor attempts to block forty cubits ahead by displaying a lease, while Urmila needs a narrow route down to the water with her washing; unstable old stakes and slippery mud combine to form a material setting in time and space. These are more than environmental images: the specific condition of the landing shapes characters' decisions. Ramani asks how a lease to catch fish can automatically obstruct public access on foot. Tara

refuses to turn a straight observational line into a legal boundary. The non-equivalence of "measurement" and "right" is a central insight here.

Renu does not want her complaint about the enclosed path merged into Ramani's application for shared fishing rights. Their concerns relate to the same pond but their interests differ: public access and women's participation in fishing labour. The wet bundle borne on Urmila's body adds social significance; a boundary concerning water use is not merely a line on a map, but a practical obstruction to a worker's movement. The decision to remove a measuring rope temporarily, keep the washing route open and await the original annex to the lease is a real but limited achievement. The entire lease is not declared void, and Ramani's name has not yet been added to the rights document.

Rama Karna's Office: Resistance to Fabricated Consent

The fourteenth segment opens in Rama Karna's office. She rejects an oral suggestion to complete the register quickly with the words "the family has consented," because no actual signatures have been obtained. This small refusal gives the politics of administrative evidence a concrete form. Rama requests the original references for two office columns: "licence" and "family representative." A computer-generated sealed copy is not the ultimate expression of public entitlement; the original order, annex and individual consent still need inspection. Five altered identities appear here in their first clearly administrative form. Rama calls them five differences requiring verification, not five crimes.

Rozi Lalbegi's religious self-identification has been inferred from the occupation named in a cleaning contract. She asks for the right to declare it herself. Her application is acknowledged, but the original entry is not immediately amended. Rita Ekka's earlier testimony has been converted into a guarantee for someone else's debt. A shared letter in a name or the matching of a relationship does not amount to a signature accepting indebtedness. Rama labels the supplied duplicate "copy submitted by claimant," not "verified contract." The real prospect of harm—wages withheld or wrongful collection—is described, but no final relief has been ordered. Such limitations on what the facts establish are an important formal strength of the novel.

Mother and Daughter: The Ethics of Time

Naira returns to her mother with only a blank comparison form. A person may have changed a name for safety, may know nothing of the change, or may have undergone coercion: the three possibilities call for different approaches to an interview. Sarita writes on the new comparison sheet herself that the private original was shown for inspection, not authorised

for complete publication. This written boundary is the plot's final material event. In the closing scene Ramani teaches her daughter to measure a fishing net; the application to add her name to the rights document still awaits an answer. Learning does not suspend life, and awaiting paperwork is not the achievement of justice.

The chapter proceeds from morning inspection of the original through midday measurement at the pond and office conversations to private writing at night. It contains no independent scene in the ancient epic period. Although the narrative of "The Original Page" has several centres, it never abandons the limits of Sarita and Naira's knowledge. One limitation recurs: many events are absorbed into classifications of "original/copy/application," leaving rather less space for the mud on site, the river's smell and the wet worker's time. Nevertheless, the combination of a document's material existence with purposeful silence regarding privacy and rights distinguishes this chapter.

Chapter 87 — Five Changed Identities

The Image of Five Pouches: Confidentiality and Professional Remuneration

The chapter opens with five white pouches in Nasim Idrisi's tailoring shop. The colours of their linings distinguish the papers inside, not the people named on them. Outside, a young man displays a clipping about five altered entries and demands evidence of an alleged "gang of pseudonyms." Nasim responds correctly: the discovery of discrepancies in five names on the same list does not prove that five people committed a crime together. The tailor's measurement book, the committee's private papers and the public attendance register are three different records. In this sequence the craft acquires firm commercial terms: confidentiality is not merely a gift but a service involving time, materials, wages and responsible custody.

Nasim enters separate charges for the cloth, lining, thread and sewing of the five pouches for Naira, and seeks written approval from the investigating committee. The public account of expenditure will give the number of pouches, not the names they contain. The overgeneralised phrase "transparency versus confidentiality" thus receives a practical division. The spending of public funds may be examined, but a customer's illness, residential address and private measurements need not be published. The later consequence appears in the payment voucher after Vinita Kesharwani intervenes. This conjunction of professional independence and individual rights is the chapter's social craftsmanship.

Five Contexts: Different Reasons, Different Evidence

At the first meeting Sugandha explains that she works under her current name and that publication of her former home address would put her in danger. She recounts her experience but does not want her account of fear recorded as an offence already established by investigation. She seeks continuity of wages under her present name and verification by a restricted circle of authorised persons. Naira does not mistake her presence at a meeting for permission to publish. Nasim places the documents in a pouch without disclosing the old name in a public comment. In this first voice, a "changed name" is a rights-based strategy for safety and livelihood.

Zahir's story is different. He testifies that an intermediary entered his attendance under another name without his knowledge. Two transportation slips and the names of three coworkers are available to check what he is owed; the intermediary's original ledger has not yet been seen. The claim of an imposed change therefore requires examination.

Zahir prohibits publication of his coworkers' private addresses but refuses to surrender his arrears. It would be contradictory to prescribe the same solution for Sugandha's self-chosen change of name and Zahir's unauthorised change of attendance. The narrative establishes this distinction within personal dialogue.

Devaki's concern is to distinguish the registration of a parent at birth from a contact address. She wants her mother named as the contact person, not a fictitious erasure of her paternal ancestry. An office questionnaire saying "father changed" is corrected, and Devaki signs the revised statement herself. This small event of rewriting becomes a criticism of patriarchal record-keeping: a male family member's name is not invariably a safe address for correspondence. The precise narrative point is that the social relationship has not changed; what differs is the claim regarding an available and authorised channel of communication.

Mangala meets the investigators at the workshop. A second name had been entered in a relief camp for reasons of safety, but two documents bearing different names do not establish that relief was received twice. One slip records presence and the other actual distribution. Mangala says, on the basis of documents she supplies, that payment was received once; final reconciliation of the government accounts remains outstanding. She keeps the originals in her own iron chest. She wants public correction, not a marketplace filled with her private history. The temporal layers of relief are important: the date of the earlier calamity and the date of the present public accusation differ. Protection through a name once described as helpful can later become the basis for alleging suspicious benefits.

Kamli becomes the fifth voice by telephone. A temporary name was used for medical relief, and the medicine register under one name and assistance letter under another have prompted an allegation that she obtained treatment meant for a different person. She accepts confidential verification of dosage and dates, but not the circulation of her illness in the marketplace. She has received no written assurance about whether a public correction would print her former name again, so she refuses to have her telephone account treated as a complete official statement. The fifth pouch remains empty. This emptiness indicates neither inactivity nor the accused person's absence; the terms of custody of the information are yet to be determined. That is a genuine event and outcome.

The Meaning of Different Evidence: Official Authority to Amend Remains Unclear

Three individuals speak in the reading room, Mangala at the workshop and Kamli by telephone. The location of dialogue is itself part of consent.

No identical questionnaire is imposed on everyone; the wording of questions, the place for storing originals and the limits of public summaries follow the individuals' wishes. Nevertheless, these five accounts alone cannot establish the lawful sequence by which the five municipal entries were officially altered. Rama wants separate scrutiny of the original entries, the modifying officer's authority and the notification procedure. A covering letter marked "restricted circulation for safety" may demonstrate a proposal; it cannot replace five signed orders. The narrative's "signals of change" should not be converted into either a count of crimes or a survey of philosophical achievements.

The young man carrying the red clipping sends out a correction, but two copies of the earlier clipping continue to circulate. Digital repetition and the unequal speeds of error and correction are particular narrative problems of this period. Speaking a correct statement once does not instantly erase an earlier false one. Nasim's observation—that the receipt for cloth may be public, but not the customer's measurements—humanises an otherwise formal dispute about the right to information. Rama and Nasim each speak from institutional authority or professional responsibility; neither thereby becomes the owner of another person's story.

Savitri, Vinita and Other Questions Beyond the Central Circle

Savitri Sardar moved villages after a flood; her current address and the date of her old relief claim must remain distinct. Relocation is not the merger of two persons. An attendance slip must not be mistaken for a distribution receipt. In Vinita Kesharwani's family business, the same sum appears as a loan in two separate ledgers. Final reconciliation is pending, but a written undertaking to investigate the duplication has been received. These matters are not a newly discovered "sixth" crime in the five-person identity dispute, but another social setting for similar methodological problems of names and liabilities. The narrator brings many citizens into one urban narrative space. This allows social breadth, while risking the reduction of characters to a succession of "cases."

In the final exchange Naira tells Kabir that she has found not an answer but the limits of how an answer may be given. Sarita insists that what a person has not said must not appear as a "zero" in the public summary. Silence may mean lack of evidence, unwillingness to speak, fear or refusal; no single meaning can be assigned without permission. The high achievement of the narrative method is the narrator's acknowledgment of limits to knowledge. Linguistic beauty emerges from objects: a craftworker's thread, the stalk of a bel leaf, a loose bicycle screw and flour paste. The limitation remains familiar: the characters' unusually coherent

language of procedure sometimes makes the disorderly voices of real struggles over power sound alike. Even so, the chapter's impartial achievement is its resistance to turning five persons into five fixed "categories of life."

Chapter 88 — Fourteen Discrepancies

Counting Numbers and Counting Meanings: Not Fourteen "People"

The chapter begins with wet shoes, traces of mud and a half-damp covering letter in the municipal office. Rama asks whether the figure refers to fourteen people, fourteen names or fourteen errors. Naira lifts fourteen plain slips and explains that they represent fourteen matters to investigate. From the outset the narrative resists overreading its own title. Counts of epic war often seek numbers of troops or measures of loss; here a number does not assign blame but organises administrative inquiry. Rama halts Devshankar's proposal to resolve everything at once: an erroneous death entry for a living person and a protected home address present different problems. Numerical equality is not causal or judicial equality.

Naira makes four piles: writing and matching; classification and authority; transactions and attendance; access and protection. Rama leaves a fifth, blank sheet for disputed facts. This is a method of investigation internal to the story. Crucially, its classification is provisional, not a final judgment. At one point Rama totals four plus three plus four plus two and obtains thirteen; separating the water-lease annex from the question of public access produces the fourteenth slip. A common file contains two independent applications. Counting itself becomes a narrative event. The reader watches a list being prepared, crossed out and reorganised, as if administrative truth were not delivered ready-made from heaven.

The Water Lease: Access, Participation and Safety

Renu Gondhi brings an appeal against the obstruction of a public route; Ramani Bind raises women's joint participation in fishing rights. A red line on a map, an incomplete abstract of the lease, a safety rope and a letter written after an alleged unauthorised entry have different sources and dates. Renu asks where the duration of the safety restriction and a safe alternative route are recorded. Ramani refuses to appropriate Renu's right of passage in the name of fishing-net rights. Read as environmental narrative, the material risks of water and aquatic livelihood coexist. Public access to the landing does not mean sending everyone onto treacherous mud. The characters themselves show children a safe footpath. Ethical entitlement and risk reduction are not opposites but mutually necessary conditions.

The original water lease, signatures, map annex and renewal page are requested; copying charges will be paid. Rama acknowledges Renu's and Ramani's separate applications. Neither has the private enclosure been proved illegal nor has the claim for women's shared fishing rights been

accepted. A purported representative of the lessee displays half a photograph: the fee is legible, but the boundary annex has been cut off. Ramani refuses to base a claim upon half a photograph. The narrative makes "place" not a picture but an active relationship of rights. In the final scene Ramani tells her daughter that the right of passage still needs to be written down; the mud of the opening returns in the knot of the fishing net and the moving end of the rope.

Social Classification: The Difference Between Description, Accusation and Self-Declaration

A discrepancy between Anita Chaupal's original application and the office entry for social category has been established, but the person responsible for the later digital alteration is unknown. A clerk attempts to determine Anita's true classification by showing a different relative's category. She raises the right to rely on her own original application. A scholarship deadline is approaching, but the provisional slip reading "classification under dispute" is not a final certificate. When the objection receipt later describes her as having "falsely declared caste," Anita has the language amended: "Discrepancy between the applicant's original particulars and the office entry; cause unknown." This is a decisive linguistic event. The alteration is not cosmetic editing: the subject of accusation shifts from the individual to the need for institutional investigation.

Part of Niranjan Kisan's family name has slipped into the occupation field of a digital form. He does cultivate land, but surname and occupational category are different. A bank-linked account is frozen, and the municipality lacks authority to decide the bank's financial action. An authorised name-matching letter is prepared, but the suspended grant has not been released. Rozi Lalbegi's religion has been inferred from an occupation in sanitation; the right of self-declaration is a separate issue. Treating all three matters as routine corrections of "misspelled names" would erase social differences among persons, communities and administration. In a narratological analogy, similarly completed forms are not reasons proving one identical proposition; each field has a different delimiting relationship, an avacchedaka. This care with categories is the novel's conceptual success.

Debt, Attendance, Medicine: Not a Single Category

The transaction pile among the fourteen inquiries contains Zahir's attendance, Vinita Kesharwani's duplicated loan, the allegation that Rita Ekka's testimony was made into a loan guarantee, and Kamli's protected medical register. All four have financial or benefit-related implications, but they require different methods of proof: the employer's original list

and day-by-day labour for Zahir; the actual amount entered in two ledgers for Vinita; the original agreement and signature for Rita; and confidential authorised medical comparison for Kamli. Consent to verify medicine confidentially is not an order to disclose a medical history at a public meeting. A changed name does not prove that an allowance was received twice, and a name appearing on a testimony page does not prove acceptance of a debt.

Naira adds a column for time-sensitive harm. Rising water for Renu, a scholarship deadline for Anita and the seed subsidy date for Niranjan involve different forms of urgency. This is an especially meaningful narrative device. Institutional time is not a neutral sequence on a clock; delay produces distinct damage to a person's body, education and livelihood. The crisis of missing or incomplete copies of warnings in the preceding Bhishma Parva is ethically connected here with receiving a response in time. But no actual calculation of the relative rates of harm appears in the source text; criticism must acknowledge both the urgency created by the episode and the absence of measurement.

Limits of the Slip, the Public Summary and Digital Rumour

Rama decides that the public copy listing the fourteen matters must bear the warning "not a list of guilty persons." On the young man's information network, the red clipping is already circulating as "fourteen guilty names," and Naira corrects the false equivalence. The chapter continues the network of digital circulation from Chapter 87. Five changed identities and fourteen discrepancies are not numbers in one category. Nor have Sarita's twenty-six visible names and her protected twenty-seventh name all entered the municipality's lists. This explicit fact in the original text must remain central to criticism, for the numbers in the chapter titles invite the reader to invent a false "complete arithmetic." Naira issues the correction within the limits of publication consent, without publicising others' illnesses, settlements or signatures.

A schoolchild's mother asks a question that reveals the lived injury caused by a "mistake in a name": who will restore the months of education lost even after an eventual correction? Naira does not turn this experienced harm into a fifteenth official case without investigation. This narrative refusal broadens the right to be heard in public history while checking excessive official sample-making. Yet the succession of different lives through one office and applications that remain unresolved slows the dramatic pace. From a literary perspective the crowd of voices depicts a wider society, but often confines each person's inner conflict to a brief conversation. That limitation should be acknowledged alongside the achievement.

The Grey Death Folder: Controlled Foreshadowing of the Next Plot Thread

In the twenty-eighth segment Rama finds a slip recording active transactions together with an entry marked "dead" in an old death-notification cover. The beneficiary is unclear. She does not insert the new material among the fourteen cases; she files it separately in a grey folder, with a note to check its original source and date. The verified fact is narrow: a discrepancy has been found between a death notification and a transaction slip. It would be unwarranted to conclude that the deceased person is alive, a murder has occurred, or the beneficiary's identity is known. The new folder foreshadows the next chapter of Karna Parva; it signals the beginning of an inquiry, not a verdict on a crime.

In the final segment Ramani loosens a knot in the net while her daughter asks about writing down their names. Cutting a rope is simple; establishing the right to use a path in writing is difficult. Through this scene the novel calls for movement beyond the negative formulation of a rule—"this is wrong"—towards positive construction: when, whose access, what safety, whose credit? The visual curve from mud on wet shoes to the shifting rope of the net is complete, but the rights dispute remains open. This structural incompletion matters: the first four chapters of Karna Parva establish ethical boundaries on knowledge rather than reveal a culprit.

Karna Parva / Sundara Kanda: Joint Critical Assessment of Chapters 85–88

The Order of Story and Narration, and Dual Temporality

These four chapters create a progression that defines limits to knowledge rather than solving a mystery in a single linear movement. Chapter 85 has an explicit sequence of the ancient veranda of Radha, Karna and Adhiratha, modern Videhapur, and a return to the ancient scene. Chapters 86–88 discuss the past through written records, memory and present investigation within the modern narrative strand; they do not return to an independent ancient scene in Hastinapura. It would therefore be inappropriate to accept an earlier indication of "dual-temporal intertextuality" for Chapters 87–88 as a literal structural fact. Their actual construction of time consists primarily of rereading old records in the present. This distinction is important for narratological analysis of time: an old letter or page is not automatically a narrated scene at a separate level of the past.

The internal sequence is coherent: Chapter 85 sets the two distinct truths of birth and upbringing beside one another; Chapter 86 distinguishes original and copy both materially and in terms of rights; Chapter 87 presents five social reasons underlying apparently similar "changed names"; and Chapter 88 examines fourteen applications of discrepancy. The numbers rise without automatically increasing the number of actual events. The entry of a price in Chapter 85 and an administrative investigation in Chapter 88 are different kinds of change. The grey death folder in Chapter 88 opens another narrative thread; together, the first four chapters establish the mental discipline required to assess the next body of evidence. The reader's initial curiosity shifts from "What is the mystery?" towards "When this much is known, how much may rightly be said?"

Focalisation, Voice and the Diversity of Evidence

The centres of narration move among Radha's domestic labour and Karna's injured aspirations in Chapter 85; the limits of Sarita and Naira's joint inspection in Chapter 86; the five individuals' different modes of encounter in Chapter 87; and Rama and Naira's investigatory work alongside the embodied experience of the fishing net at the pond in Chapter 88. Each character specifies not only "do not speak falsely" but also the position from which they are authorised to speak. Consent, shelter, wages, debt, religion, social category, a flood-time address and medical confidentiality cannot all be reduced to the word "identity."

Equally, perception, verbal testimony, accounts, inference and private experience should not be treated as one undifferentiated class of evidence. The novel's strength is its recognition of this broad epistemic inequality, while analysis of the relationship between evidence and narration gives language to these distinct limits of subject matter.

Epic Resonance, Indian Poetics and the Historical Perspective

The familiar public question about Karna's birth is expanded through Radha's labour and the truth of upbringing. This imaginative epic episode should not be represented as a direct quotation from the original Mahabharata. The possibility of karuna rasa lies in the mother's silence and Kabir's blank space for a name; a touch of shanta occurs in the folk song shared by Radha and Dhairi and in the evening meal. Artificial declarations of bibhatsa or vira would be inappropriate. Dhvani becomes powerful when a damp notebook, sewing thread, brass box and bamboo fishing net disclose meanings through themselves; overt instruction weakens suggestion. On the test of aucitya, the refusal to turn personal testimony into a legal ruling is effective, but linguistic differentiation diminishes when every character begins to speak in the same meticulously ordered language of evidence.

The Videha parallel-history perspective is not a machine for adding ever more caste or community names to a list. Radha's grain, Dhairi's sewing, Kiran's sharecropping, Ramani's fishing rights, Rozi's self-description, Zahir's transport labour and Kamli's medical slip represent different kinds of work, experience and entitlement. The novel's social range becomes truly creative when individuals consent—or refuse consent—to the public use of their circumstances. A problem arises when many subjects become little more than examples in short office scenes; this counterargument must be examined again in the book's final evaluation.

Achievements, Limits and the Next Critical Question

The principal achievement of these four chapters is their analysis of the social production of supposed evidence. Although "The Original Page" is a material original, it does not contain indisputable knowledge. The five persons in "Five Changed Identities" do not share one intention; the fourteen investigatory matters in "Fourteen Discrepancies" are not a count of guilty people. The living bond of care between Karna and Radha is independent of any conclusion about biological birth. A limitation is that many characters repeat the same cautionary idiom, and social injury sometimes remains in the form of unresolved office applications for rather too long. Procedural ethics cannot by itself replace the human intensity of an event. Nevertheless, where the story enters the smells and textures of

objects and the intimacy of family memory, that limitation is partly overcome.

The next test will not be to derive a ready-made conclusion from Chapter 89's title, "Four Alive, Four Dead," but to determine the real source of Chapter 88's grey folder, its separate death entries, the beneficiary of the transactions and the factual status of possible fraud. An event, a crime and the identification of a victim should be recorded only after distinct inquiries. That discipline is the critical conclusion of the first four chapters of Karna Parva.

Chapter 89 — Four Alive, Four Dead

Blue and Ochre: Classification as an Ethical Event

Before the municipal office window opens, Rama Karna separates blue and ochre slips into two trays. This modest arrangement of objects dramatises the evidentiary structure of the narrative. Blue is labelled "Declared dead, personally alive"; ochre, "Death confirmed, account active." Without this division, the story could become a sensational claim that eight dead people were still earning money. Rama and Naira separate what must first be proved. Four living persons wrongly declared dead pose one question; continuing transactions in the names of four truly deceased persons, their causes and actual recipients, pose another. Confusing the headings would simultaneously demean living people and accuse bereaved families. Classification is therefore not just an administrative convenience but the first action against injustice.

The first blue case concerns Sarita's public appearance and the receipt acknowledging her objection. The second concerns Fakira's suspended railway pass and daily earnings. A woman from a relief settlement brings two dated treatment receipts and her own testimony for the third, but refuses permission to disclose her name. Fourth, a young bundle-carrier at the bus stand presents receipts for wages earned after he was declared dead, while asking that his workplace not be publicised. The four living people are not interchangeable copies. Sarita's evidence concerns a public meeting and payment for private work; Fakira's concerns a service pass; the third woman's concerns medicine and dignity; the young man's concerns earlier wages and pressure from a contractor. Officials may need proof of the statement "I am alive," but that necessity does not open every aspect of a person's life to public exhibition. The woman's hours of sewing and the youth's past wages expose class differences within the category of "living persons."

The ochre pile demands a different logical discipline. A new prescription appears alongside the death certificate issued seventeen years earlier for Sarita's husband. Dispensing medicine does not establish who received it, because the collector's signature is absent from the copy. Interest continues to be deducted from another deceased labourer's savings account, perhaps under an automatic standing order; this does not establish that someone personally withdrew the money. A family claims to have paid outstanding dues on the fishing lease of a third deceased person. In the fourth case a fee is entered against a pledged object, but the receipt naming whoever collected the property is missing. The four active entries suggest four distinct causal chains. Converting "an account remains active" into "the deceased is committing fraud" confuses reason and conclusion. Instead of a

colourful disclosure, the novel enumerates the original registers, permissions and signatures still needed.

Rejecting the Simple Arithmetic of "Eight Crimes"

In the seventh segment Devshankar asks, "Eight crimes?" Naira answers, "Eight questions, eight paths of investigation." This is the central intellectual caution of Karna Parva expressed in dialogue. The reader has a number, but a number alone reveals neither the kind of offence, intention nor perpetrator. Eight documentary entries begin the specification of subjects; conviction is a proposed conclusion whose valid reason and relation of inference still need testing. Bodily presence, a receipt for later work and official acknowledgment offer distinct kinds of evidence; none by itself automatically authorises cancelling an individual's original entry. The novel thus presents the conflict between administrative prudence and the slow injustice of administration. Despite substantive questions, the four living people's death markers remain formally uncorrected.

Light grows around the corners of the trays while the empty space between them remains wide. This image is significant: illumination can increase information without removing gaps in knowledge or inequalities of evidence. By the twenty-fifth and final segment, the office has developed two streams of correspondence. Blue concerns living persons, histories of mistaken death entries and possible interim restoration of services; ochre concerns proof of death, the origins of transactions, beneficiaries and heirs. This is genuine progress in organising work, not a verdict. The blue-and-ochre files are not self-evidently truthful government categories; the narrator deliberately constructs a visible distinction so that the ethical effects of classification become legible. A critical question remains whether so neat a separation oversimplifies life, although the four divergent slips in each pile temper the categories' rigidity.

Public Benefaction, Personal Names and Pledges: The Logic of the Ensemble Scenes

Among the eight cases Sudha Rai postpones announcing a donation for a school veranda because the proposed building line crosses a narrow path used daily by a tenant family. This reveals a third dimension of evidentiary ethics: an intention to promote public welfare does not establish the absence of prior communal rights of use. The tenant woman explains that she needs enough space to carry a cot for her sick mother-in-law. A child's toy wheel getting stuck during measurement offers a clue, not a complete measure of the cot. Sudha revises the donation announcement and pays the day wages of workers whose time was wasted, but does not pay the full bill for work never performed. Such distinctions replace glorification of the

donor with accountability. The tenant speaks independently of her husband, bringing her right to testify into the public donation record.

The office treats Basanti Pan's chosen self-description as a set of "convenient synonyms" for several caste labels. Basanti demands separate fields for the name she uses herself and the official classification. The first line is entered on the acknowledgment, but the final certificate is not yet changed. Reducing the historical weight of caste names to reservation rules or bureaucratic codes would ignore the conflict between lived language, the right to one's name and institutional records. At Sharda Kasaudhan's pawnshop, separation of three accounts and cash refund of duplicated interest are immediate verifiable corrections, whereas two other pledges and an ownership dispute remain undecided. Nahid Moghal's maternal-family letter and the name "Livari" used for a river again delimit the evidence: consent regarding maternal land may be contested, but a river's present boundary cannot be established from an older name alone. Nahid refuses permission to copy the letter, and her privacy is not labelled evidence of deception.

Although four short episodes depart from the death register announced by the title, they share one principal issue: distinguish the beneficiary, owner, claimant and person entitled to speak before giving or taking resources. Sudha's gift, Basanti's name, Sharda's interest and Nahid's letter all involve the danger of someone testifying on behalf of another person's rights. The artistic limitation is that the rapid movement from eight principal slips to four subplots repeatedly divides the reader's emotional involvement. The impulse to pause and state a social principle slows the action. Economic situations are rendered visibly, but some sentences resemble operational directions for conducting a hearing.

The Manually Repeated "Dead" Mark: The Investigation's Real Turning Point

In the nineteenth segment a digital change history shows that "dead" was manually selected once again after Sarita first objected. This is more important new evidence than a supposed routine error. The computer log establishes a manual action, not the particular actor, instructing authority or intention. Devshankar immediately suspects conspiracy, but Naira checks that inference. Rama orders preservation of the original digital alteration log. This is a real narrative turning point: deliberate manipulation becomes a possibility alongside administrative negligence, but "the criminal has been caught" remains untrue. In the twentieth segment a reporter sensationalises the "eight dead"; Rama corrects the false conflation in the public summary. Public circulation of knowledge

has become part of the investigation, and the speed of media exceeds the pace of proof.

At night in Sarita's kitchen, her insistence that her husband's death must not be reversed into a claim that he is alive echoes the first chapter, “The Dead Man's Kitchen.” Conflating the dead husband, the living Sarita, medicine distribution and widow's entitlements would inflict twofold violence. Before seeing Subhadra, Kabir asks who possesses the right to tell the story; thus the transition from Chapter 89 to Chapter 90 is prepared by a domestic question, not by the numbering of files. Rama ties up the papers at the close; whether the office will learn to account for people's time remains open. The chapter notably distinguishes the number of questions from the number of culprits. Its repeated “no proof, no accusation” sometimes restricts the reader's freedom to infer, but the harms are real enough to prevent this caution from becoming merely theoretical.

Chapter 90 — Subhadra's Conditions

The Chest, the Chairs and the Time of Conversation

Subhadra oils a chest's hinge and lifts its lid, but instead of opening the cotton bag inside she wipes two chairs. The sequence creates compact narrative symbolism. The closed chest invites an unknown birth-story; the chairs critically revise that invitation: conditions for two people to speak come before possession of an object. She writes “Conditions for speaking,” fixing her voice in words. This narrative authority prevents her from becoming merely a keeper of an old secret or an instrument of final disclosure. She controls when and how much to say, the safety of other people's names and the possibility of resuming the conversation. Kabir arrives not with a gift or a book but with his notebook and water bottle. These ordinary objects replace an overwrought reunion and balance an unequal encounter: the questioner's desire is real but does not make the respondent indebted.

Subhadra stipulates four conditions: no recordings without permission; no disclosure of names, addresses, birth dates or pictures of letters; she decides when a conversation must pause; and permission to question does not imply permission to publish. Kabir immediately objects that he should still be able to write his own memories. Subhadra distinguishes confidentiality of what she says from his independent recollection. That disagreement matters: her conditions are not an absolute legal shield of silence and may themselves be examined. Naira later suggests adding, “If legal evidence is requested, separate advice must be obtained,” and Subhadra accepts the addition in her own written document. Privacy is not boundless authority to suppress truth; public and legal demands have their particular procedures. The novel does not oppose women's rights and truth as simple antagonists.

Biological Questions alongside Memories of Care

Kabir says he wants to fill the blank in his birth history without erasing the life of the family that raised him. This echoes “Radha's Labour” (Chapter 85) across a different temporal setting. In the ancient Radha–Karna episode the directly experienced duration of nurture differs from an unknown prehistory of birth; in Kabir's contemporary problem, the focal points are older papers, shared recollection and the safety of the living Subhadra. It would contradict the text to identify “Kabir is Karna,” whether as a matter of caste or reincarnation. The intertextual resemblance is thematic: one name may disclose a prehistory but cannot shrink the long life of fostering.

Kabir asks how any facts emerging from Subhadra's story could be verified. One condition is that he not suddenly arrive at any other living person's house without warning. Here ethical narratology marks a difficult distinction: a person's means of exercising a right to know may intrude unwillingly upon the lives of others. Subhadra falls silent at a moment of her choosing without dismissing Kabir's agitation as false. In the eighteenth segment she makes clear that her past loneliness does not give her power to silence him, just as his present impatience does not authorise him to command the history of her body. The ethical complexity lies in this double refusal. A label such as "privacy protection" alone would flatten its emotional force.

Subhadra does not open the letter in the chest. She produces only an envelope from a drawer with half a written name and a stained date, which Kabir does not touch. The existence of a name on an envelope, evidence that something was sent, the actual identity of a household and what Subhadra may testify later are four distinct levels of proof. She says she does not yet know the entire significance of the old letter. The glimpse is a familiar suspense mechanism, yet the uncertainty of the object is carefully established; readers must resist making a complete person out of half a name. In the twentieth segment she asks whether a blank in the document arose because its writer did not know or was prevented from writing. Different proof would be needed in each case. This distinction opens the possibility of institutional power before constructing individual blame.

Ownership of a Bangle, the Marriage Register and the River's Memory

Beginning in the sixth segment, the chapter expands from Subhadra's memories to the present rights claims of other women. At Kamla Thakur's shop an elderly woman brings an old bangle, while a young man brings a family debt ledger. A bent floral design on the metal can help identify the piece but does not finally prove ownership. Kamla creates separate receipts for ownership and debt. The older woman's claim is recorded and sale of the bangle temporarily suspended; it is not returned to her, and the young man's debt is not cancelled. Kamla's observation that metal composition and proprietary rights are distinct demonstrates the proper limits of craft knowledge. Practical expertise does not confer omniscience about inheritance law. Nor is the jeweller merely an expert witness: she decides herself how to handle the shop key, custody and customer records, making professional autonomy part of the narrative.

An ink blot has removed a maternal female relative's name from Nilima Nurang's copy of a marriage register, while paternal and marital identities survive. Nilima asks not to insert a "new name" but to restore

the maternal name already present in the original record. An invitation, a private letter signed by the mother and the official original register are three different evidentiary sources. Permission to inspect the bound original is pending and no correction has been ordered. The register's language privileges two lines of a woman's life unequally. The case cannot be reduced to "women's education" or "a mistake in a name." The placename "Nima" on the marriage document does not establish a river's location. Maternal identity and geographical memory of the mother's village are historical sources with different jurisdictions.

Tulsi Donwar's land documents for two villages, identifying "Balan" and "Bhutahi Balan" separately, bring the examination outdoors. Tara Mallik measures the present surface at a sand landing while distinguishing earlier erosion, debts and current possession. Vehicle weight on wet sand, the teenage worker's fear of losing half his transport wage, and Tulsi holding the rope keep the story from being confined to a desk. Work may have to stop for the teenager's safety, but who pays for the suspended hours remains a separate issue. Tulsi blocks an office proposal to treat two river names as one watercourse; the only decision is a date for a fresh boundary inspection. In environmental narratology the river is an active cause of debt, movement and bodily risk rather than scenery. Traditional recollection is respected without allowing it to settle every cartographic claim.

"Giving Time" versus "Giving an Answer": Reordering Narrative Time

From the seventeenth through twenty-first segments, Subhadra and Kabir's second meeting returns the story to its centre. Kabir writes three questions—"name," "time" and "whom to tell"—which Subhadra will not resolve simultaneously. The narrative does not simply delay the name; it distributes the time in which answers may be given. Readers approach revelation and are checked again, not by arbitrary authorial stubbornness but by the character's autonomy and security of evidence. Kabir's exhaustion is heard and Subhadra's becomes visible. Naira provides a copy of the consent page without transcribing private birth information, resisting the journalist's temptation to own knowledge. The new bond is recognised not as "an adequate answer" but as "an adequate beginning."

The final five segments weave together papers from three households, a shifting bench in a bookshop, a shelf in a possible room and the everyday boiling of tea. The ending is more than a restful pause after suspense. Kabir and Naira discuss making separate spaces for two books and wonder whose name to put on a shared volume. Kabir prefers first to put the book in place without a name: a small shift from possessing memory toward common use. Karna's unknown origin, Radha's domestic labour, Subhadra's boundaries and the books of Kabir's own life come into one frame. The

scene finds artistic stability in shared domestic action rather than in solving the document.

A contrary assessment is necessary. The successive legal and social stories of Kamla, Nilima and Tulsi repeatedly interrupt the principal intimate dialogue. Most characters speak in terms of written procedure, separate files or graduated consent, risking an improbably uniform, educated caution. Subhadra's silence, Kabir's frustration and Tulsi's sand-soaked shoes nevertheless preserve bodily and experiential variety against regulatory diction. The same feature is both the chapter's limitation and strength: delayed answers loosen the rhythm, but give character autonomy real narrative power.

Chapter 91 — A Convenient Error

“Status Closed” at the Kitchen Door: The Economic Displacement of a Living Person

At dawn Sarita spreads old receipts across a mat in her kitchen. Rainwater splashed upon them overnight, but the papers have survived. She places her petition asserting that she is alive and her claim for three months' unpaid copying work in separate envelopes. The distinction gives the division in “Four Alive, Four Dead” a new economic significance. The erroneous death marker has not only hurt her identity; it provides an administrative pretext for withholding remuneration for labour. Yet the causal order linking the marker and the outstanding payment must still be investigated. Sarita separates her handwritten delivery receipts, the old page-count register and the government's status letter. Neither personal account nor official seal is automatically decisive; their relationship is the issue.

The third segment protects a crucial division in the main plot: Sarita's three months of transcribing flood-damaged papers for the municipal library are not the same as her three days copying Ishan's philosophical manuscript. Conflating those projects would destroy their specific evidence of time, material and payment. During the three-month undertaking Sarita deciphered writing obscured by stains, and asked others to check particular lines. “Copying” becomes a skill of textual conservation rather than mechanical transcription. Her labour helped preserve the library's historical memory, yet the archival system declared the woman dead and denied her wages. This internal irony is the chapter's strongest insight.

In the fifth segment the accounts ledger approves three instalments but shows “status closed” beside Sarita's name in the payment column. A neighbouring paper says “remaining transcription-editing completed by external services,” with the sum entered under a contract for Giridhari Sah's organisation. Benefit now appears to flow in another direction. A billed sum, however, does not prove a bank transfer; segments six through eight pursue this gap. The order issued after Sarita's final delivery mentions “remaining work” without identifying pages. The institution's bound copy and Sarita's preserved copy share a distinctive irregular blue-ink mark. This strongly indicates continuity of the same material, not a final finding of theft. Rebinding a text is a service; paying an organisation a second time for someone else's transcription raises another question. The novel distinguishes a contractor's gain from his guilt.

Proximity in Time, Acknowledged Benefit and the Limits of Accusation

The bank's confirmation in the tenth segment shows that two external instalments entered Giridhari's declared institutional account; a third was authorised but might still be stopped. Sarita's death status was manually selected again just days before these payments. Naira places the dates together without drawing a causal arrow. Two facts are visible on paper, but establishing that one caused the other needs a further link: an order, access authority or purposeful instruction. Temporal proximity does not constitute a necessary relation of inference. This offers a modern occasion for disciplined reasoning, not a quotation from a classical philosophical text. The narrative presents contemporary evidence; literary criticism uses philosophical concepts to examine it.

Giridhari acknowledges the two instalments. He itemises sorting, binding, transport and wages, identifies the balance as business income and denies changing the death entry. Self-interested testimony need not automatically be false; silence or nervousness is not proof of wrongdoing. Sarita advances a specific labour argument: payment for work that Giridhari's employees genuinely performed cannot extinguish the wages owed for writing she completed first. She does not establish her own right by denying the work of others. In the twentieth segment she herself warns that two workers employed by Giridhari may lose wages as the inquiry proceeds. She wants questionable profit investigated without cancelling the attendance or wages of those who actually sorted documents. Class justice cannot be reduced to a single individual's blame; poor employees must not be made to pay compensation for the contractor's disputed advantage.

In the twenty-first segment Rama acknowledges that she cannot confiscate money or declare guilt in place of a court or higher officer. She proposes recalculating Sarita's wages; holding the third instalment pending examination of the actual work; comparing pages underlying the first two instalments; preserving receipts for employees' genuine wages; and obtaining the original digital history of the death-status change. Giridhari's written objection is attached too. The multiplicity of recorded voices has narrative meaning: both the complainant and the person accused can be heard, and stages of judgment must not be skipped. A hearing is arranged; guilt has not been decided.

The twenty-third segment yields a “user-room” indication for the shared terminal used to select the death marker again. Individual login and the chain of orders remain incomplete. The timing of the action has been established, which advances the earlier inquiry, but the actor and intention remain unknown. A reader who overlooks the shared terminal and immediately identifies one employee would violate the evidentiary

rules of the novel. “A Convenient Error” is therefore an interrogative critical title rather than a court's judgment: who benefited, whose labour was erased, and by whose instructions? Some answers have emerged, while others still require investigation.

Genealogical Song, the Maternal-Family Letter and Ownership of Sources

From the twelfth segment Chetan Bhatt, Nahid Moghal and Anupama Sen enter the narrative. As payment for a genealogical song, Chetan has received an old sheet containing a name resembling Sarita's. A resemblance, a torn date and uncertainty about the giver's ownership prevent the sheet from proving anything in the present death-entry investigation. Chetan resolves to seek separate conditions for a document given as a gift, held in trust, offered as payment for work or used to make private life public. Oral genealogical history deserves attention, yet esteem for oral tradition does not itself create a right to copy a specific document. Sarita's central issue—credit for transcription of another's writing—reappears in Chetan's song. Labour in both cases may be original while rights still belong to the prior author or family custodian.

A proposed mortgage of Nahid's maternal-family land bears the words “family consent” without signatures. Nahid acknowledges genuine concern about debt, but demands separate examination of share ownership, the debt calculation and the consent document. The older river-name “Livari” occurs on a page but cannot establish current boundaries. Maithili words in Anupama Sen's Bengali letter do not make all its private contents public historical property. Anupama allows two lines on past book expenditure to be used with names concealed; Chetan withholds his sheet for now. Consent is not restricted to everything or nothing: it may vary by document, source and purpose. Such episodes are germane to the Videha parallel-history perspective, in which folk song, women's correspondence, local names and book copies provide evidence outside official archives, but do not extinguish source owners' privacy or creative rights.

The troublesome question is how much causal connection these three episodes have with Sarita's contract case. Anupama's letter has no current death-register name, Chetan's slip is unverified and Nahid's debt dispute is independent. They must not be claimed as established links in one secret network. They form conceptual parallels concerning permission to use sources, accounting for labour and informed consent. Their deliberate symmetry is a possible artistic weakness: each new character separates original and copy, ownership and permission, risking an overly uniform voice even in a rich interdisciplinary design. Yet Chetan's reluctance to

sing, the smell of camphor from Anupama's document and Nahid's question to her mother about an earlier season restore singular experiences beyond administrative phrasing.

Writing an Accusation: From Sarita's Voice to Institutional Power

In the twenty-seventh segment a young man tries to connect Sarita's contract dispute, the earlier false charge against Janki, Gunja's unauthorised transfer and the search for Mithun into one "complete network." Naira prevents this conflation, preparing the entrance to Chapter 92: turning unfinished investigation into sensation would blame new people without proof. In the twenty-eighth segment Sarita drafts her own accusation: arrears have been withheld; an external institution received two instalments; the person who altered the status and the source of the order remain unverified. The document identifies fact, possible causal link and uncertainty. Sarita does not remain silent, but will not assert more than the evidence supports. The woman once officially recorded as dead now independently writes questions about the rights to her labour and the profit taken by institutions.

In the closing office scene, an officer may seek to settle the matter as "just an accounting error," while the contractor may challenge the withholding of payment for legitimate work. Both are still entitled to a hearing. Rather than moral polarisation, the novel chooses the genuine incompletion of future justice. Its artistic achievement is a steadily constructed sequence: payment suspended, "remaining work" undefined, corresponding copies bearing distinctive marks, two proved bank instalments and an incomplete shared-terminal history. Its limitation is that characters frame objections with almost legal perfection at every turn, containing fear and anger within long procedural dialogues. Yet Sarita warming bread, giving a child a piece and answering incompletely when asked whether her name has been corrected keep bodily harm in view. Benefit from an error does not prove a complete conspiracy, but this injustice now has a concrete and undeniable form.

Chapter 92 — The Breaking of an Accusation

The Bamboo Mat and the Repeated Charge: The Economic Time of Justice

Janki repairs a torn bamboo mat. Caught in its weave is a printed leaflet that used two cropped faces to accuse people of stealing a child. She does not tear it up but notes the date of printing and the shopkeeper's mark, preserving the leaflet as an object of evidence. This gives the moral conflict of the novel a material dimension. Even after an earlier public correction, the allegation has been printed again: the lie is not just an offence from the past but a newly manufactured event. Saryu has changed her selling route, and customers put insulting questions in front of her granddaughter. “Defamation” is therefore no abstract loss of reputation; its effects extend through diminished sales, a girl's memory and the altered route by which someone earns a living. Janki's question, “Who will pay the price of the lie?” draws together the economic and moral strands.

Mahto, the printing-press owner, reprinted the allegation despite the earlier correction notice. He explains that a headline producing fear is easy, while a correction is difficult to phrase. It is a severe observation about the market economy of language: sensation sells quickly; caution slows narration. Yet Janki does not demand public exposure of Mahto's entire private customer ledger. Naira submits a written request to preserve order slips and payment receipts for a defined period. The right to resist wrongful publicity must not annihilate every other person's informational rights. Janki places a copy of the acknowledgment in her bag. The printing orders have not been examined and final responsibility remains undecided, but an institutional step has been taken against the risk of erasing proof.

A Disproved Allegation and Residual Investigation: Strictly Separating Three Children's Stories

At a school meeting Asad Syed brings the earlier correction notice, while Sajid Nat distinguishes three original visual scenes: rehearsal of a play, a forest gate and Sukathi's loading yard. The cropped composite made them seem one event although the original scenes came from different days and locations. The technical person who assembled the picture is unknown, but the factual grounds for calling Janki's group child thieves on the basis of these images have collapsed. This is the title's limited yet substantial meaning. One must not reduce the refutation to “nothing can be said”: the principal ground has been shown false. Conversely, who made the composite, who commissioned the new printing and what damages are payable remain open questions.

A parent asks in the sixth segment whether the child's disappearance was therefore also fictitious. Janki distinguishes three issues: Lata's son Mithun genuinely is missing; evidence shows Chameli's daughter Gunja was transported without permission to a work site; and the allegation that Janki's group stole children, built from manipulated images, is false. Criticism must preserve these divisions. One matter concerns a missing-person search, another investigation of unauthorised labour transfer, and the third a public retraction. A successful correction does not settle the other two struggles. Lata asks why her son's confidential search file should appear in the correction leaflet. Naira promises not to print his name, clothing or private leads. A grieving family's privacy and the wrongfully accused group's reputation are distinct rights to protection, not enemies.

A market-committee member demands portraits and "character certificates" for every person in Janki's group. Saryu asks why faces circulated for humiliation must now be displayed again on a stage to prove innocence. Reusing the visual machinery of violence as that of correction without consent would inflict another wound. The revised committee proposal includes removing false leaflets, posting corrections, registering financial claims separately and preventing needless disclosure of identities. Justice is more than a declaration of "no blame"; a correction must reach the public with visibility comparable to the lie. But practical compliance remains for the next day. A resolution passed is not an instantly transformed market.

Gunja's Independent Voice: Child Protection and Unlawful Appropriation of Labour

Chameli refuses to place Gunja in a public spectacle of rescue. Permission for initial safe contact has been obtained, but the return-home process is incomplete. In the child-protection office, an old rental-office register, an initial transport slip and a sewing-room receipt ledger correspond in sequence, dates and contact details. The intermediary route from office to workshop is thus no longer mere rumour. Yet who intended what, whether deception occurred and who prevented the child from leaving remain separate questions of individual criminal liability. A senior officer stops an employee from prematurely announcing that a "broker has been caught." Documentary connections have genuinely advanced the story, but not authorised a verdict.

Gunja's protected statement is not made material for the market meeting. With her permission, a worker says only that she wants to return to school, does not reject learning sewing entirely, and wants the wages she earned accounted for. Chameli answers that if Gunja willingly takes up a needle, the needle must not be treated as the sign of a crime. The story

separates illicit transfer into child labour from a wish to learn a craft. Gunja is not merely the object of adults' fight for justice; education, choice, earned wages and her future interests matter independently. However, the narrator does not give her an extensive direct first-person speech. Her wishes reach the reader through a worker. Protection may justify mediation, yet feminist and child-centred narratology can still ask how much of the girl's own voice is audible. Privacy in the plot and reduced direct speech in the artistic form remain in tension.

Lata hears before an officer that the time Gunja was at the bus stand might overlap the time Mithun was at a fairground, although there is no direct evidence that he was present. Rather than make her son's story out of Gunja's documents, she asks for separate re-examination of the original testimony about an oil shop and a torn ribbon. Her conscious refusal of grief-driven speculation shows character development. Many parents' stories can share emotional urgency without losing the distinct origins, times and places of their documents. Lata's procedure confronts the reader's appetite for an exciting "one network explains everything" narrative.

The Sikligar, the Kalar and the Distribution of Medicine: The Widening Social Reach of Accusation

In segments thirteen to fifteen Nazir Sikligar repairs ordinary farming implements. His shop has been labelled "makes weapons" because an unidentified consignment mentions "iron repairs." Before an inspector he presents dates, measurements and paid receipts for repairing sickles, hoes and metal kitchen plates. The premise that an ironworker might be capable of making weapons cannot prove that Nazir was responsible for this particular consignment. Inspectors seize no object supporting the accusation; the original waybill for the unnamed consignment is still required. Apprentice Batesar obtains a customer's consent and obscures identifying details rather than distributing an image of an entire home. Professional reputation, privacy and wages are therefore practical effects, not mere philosophical illustrations.

Bina Kalar's ancestral-property share differs from the capital she has earned in her own shop. Her brother argues that, since she runs a business, she ought to give up the ancestral share—an attempt to nullify family rights on grounds of private enterprise. Bina recognises the legitimate question of household medical bills while demanding original receipts, an allocation of debts and title documents. Elsewhere a wholesaler offers her an advance for a three-year monopoly. She refuses to mortgage the independence of her purchases even at the price of a delayed shop opening. Women's entrepreneurial autonomy is here a choice with a real cost, not a

wish. It echoes “Radha's Labour” from earlier in Karna Parva, although the women's periods, institutions and economic means are different.

Vibha Agrahari's medicine distribution brings together prices, transport, drivers' wages and patients' ability to pay. One box arouses suspicion because its outside label fails to match the distributor's slip within. The box is held and evidence safeguarded; legitimate remaining medicines are distributed in accordance with a doctor's written priorities. Aid and income are not falsely separated: Vibha offers part of her profit but makes the costs visible. An assistant tries to connect the medicine shipment to child-transfer offences because certain labels resemble one another; Vibha demands the original waybill. The irregular box is under investigation; lawful medicines have not been withheld. The story measures the power of suspicion to spread across institutions and interrupt people's necessary work against the urgency of treatment.

Announcement, Proceedings and Incomplete Correction in the Market

The meeting in segments twenty-three to twenty-six produces decisions. Mahto admits that after receiving a correction notice he nevertheless printed an accusatory leaflet without verification; he seeks time to supply numbers printed and locations of distribution. Janki wants not only an apology but a correction in the very places where she was defamed. Within its powers, the committee orders removal of the display and a correction of comparable visibility. The financial-loss application is received but compensation is not assessed; original evidence from the child-protection inquiry must be held separately; a hearing concerning the press's client is pending. These results must be distinguished: the false charge has been refuted but economic loss not wholly redressed; the intermediary route has been evidenced but there is no final criminal determination of its agents.

In the twenty-seventh segment Saryu sells a woven mat again in the marketplace, to someone who judges the knots and price. The narrator expressly warns that one sale cannot restore all her dignity. The seemingly trivial act has greater significance: a woman who was accused has resumed negotiation over the value of what she makes. The market's social gaze is not fully changed, but ordinary selling becomes central to her narrative being. The twenty-eighth segment carries Nazir's day's work, Bina's wait for ancestral documents and Vibha's receipt of lawful medicines towards separate outcomes. They do not become passive emblems after a theatrical pronouncement of “innocence”; they continue to confront unresolved decisions in their trades.

The last segment introduces another possible documentary intersection. Two stages of Gunja's intermediary route are connected by records, while

one transport serial number invites comparison with the withheld medicine box and the anonymous "iron repairs" paper. Naira does not immediately attach a person's name to a matching number; she asks for original consignment papers and the lawful owner's receipt. A possible network may become a real question for plot investigation, heightening anticipation. But similar figures do not provide an adequate necessary link between causes. The false conclusion drawn from the same "7" in Chapter 75 established a caution that is being applied afresh. The correction of earlier false allegations makes it all the more necessary.

Critical Achievement and the Uncomfortable Counterargument

The achievement of the chapter lies in refusing to treat all "accusations" as ethically identical. The manipulated visual charge against Janki has been disproved; records of Gunja's transfer are confirmed but criminal responsibility is unsettled; the accusation against Nazir based on his skills is unsupported; a real label discrepancy in a medicine box is verified but still being investigated; and Bina's inheritance rights may be suppressed through an economic quarrel. The reader learns to distinguish false accusation from genuine irregularity. The novel does not claim that any person's reputation has been completely restored.

A real artistic limit is that three episodes involving Nazir, Bina and Vibha enter the middle of Janki's struggle as successive independent lessons in "proper evidence." An overly uniform moral syntax risks breaking emotional immersion; their voices could have been more individually differentiated. The ringing of Nazir's iron, Bina's accounts drawer, the warehouse seal in Vibha's hand and knots of Saryu's mat reduce abstraction through objects. More important, the committee's written correction order does not mean effective correction in the actual market. If later chapters fail to show practical results, doubt remains justified. Even so, Saryu's small sale and Janki's acknowledged submission are real, limited outcomes.

Karna Parva / Sundara Kanda: Joint Critical Assessment of Chapters 89–92

Event Sequence: From Classification to Consequences

These four chapters form an interdependent but unequal sequence. In Chapter 89 Rama separates the false death entries for four living people from the active accounts of four deceased persons, and the manually repeated “dead” mark on Sarita's record becomes a new clue in the digital history. Chapter 90 supplies no direct documentary outcome to that investigation; the confidential meeting of Kabir and Subhadra instead establishes ethical conditions for acquiring knowledge. In Chapter 91, evidence progressively connects Sarita's erroneous death status and a contract that benefited while her wages were withheld: two bank instalments are confirmed, but motive and the digital user remain unknown. In Chapter 92 the factual refutation of the public charge against Janki produces social and economic consequences, while Gunja's unauthorised transfer and the independent search for Mithun continue. A question about “names” has gradually become one about labour, benefit, visibility and responsibility.

Changes in focalisation are no less important. Chapter 89 moves from Rama's institutional table through Sudha, Basanti, Sharda and Nahid and finally to Sarita's kitchen. In Chapter 90 the narrative moves from Subhadra's private time to Kabir's impatience, Naira's mediation and other women's property claims, concluding at an empty shelf for shared books. Chapter 91 juxtaposes the opposed testimonies of Sarita and Giridhari with the limits of Rama's official viewpoint. Chapter 92 follows the commercial injuries suffered by Janki and Saryu, the confidentiality of child-protection work and the parallel trades of Nazir, Bina and Vibha. This is not the unrestricted vision of an omniscient narrator. Information is offered through multiple scenes while pronouncements about unverified individual intention are withheld. The reader is made an investigator, not a judge with authority to punish.

Four Source Relationships and the Meaning of Proof

Four qualitative states of evidence become visible: first, underlying status, such as direct personal presence and certified death; second, custody of documents, originals and copies, and permission from persons; third, the possible causal relation among payment, logs of time and institutional advantage; and fourth, factual refutation of public charges and the distinct legal authority required for criminal inquiry. Terms relating to subject, proposed conclusion, reason, inconclusive reasoning and unestablished

grounds can assist interpretation, but invoking classical categories cannot substitute for a final judicial or administrative finding. The principle of aucitya in Indian poetics raises the question whether constant explanation of evidence dries out voices. The answer is mixed. Some characters reason with excessive legal neatness, but Subhadra's closed chest, Sarita's bread, Nahid's letter, Janki's mat and Saryu's woven goods retain the story's sensuous body. Compassion, moral anger, fear and limited relief take shape through these material details.

The Radha–Karna relationship earlier in Karna Parva supplies an ethical ground of "truth of upbringing versus the prehistory of birth." Chapter 90 translates that theme into the contemporary rights of Kabir and Subhadra. The link with "Karna" does not disappear because Chapters 89, 91 and 92 have no separate ancient Mahabharata scene. The public meaning of a name, the recognition of a person and the value of work beyond inherited titles recur in altered forms. The distinction between historical equivalence and narrative re-use must nevertheless be upheld.

Achievements of Form and an Overall Reservation

All four chapters mark incomplete outcomes openly. The four living people's death entries have not been formally corrected; Subhadra's letter is not fully revealed; Sarita has not received her wages and the digital offender remains unidentified; Mithun has not been found and Gunja has not returned home; Janki's compensation has not been fixed. This is not the same as saying there has been no progress. Proof of two bank transfers, original consent for a conversation, preservation of printing orders, evidence of the intermediary route and an official resolution for public correction are real changes. Narrative density must be assessed by their significance, not by a mechanical count of incidents per thousand words.

The danger of repetition is substantial. Distinctions of original and copy, name and right, application and verdict, matching number and different cause appear in explicit analytical speech across many chapters. In a 216-chapter novel, such methodological rigour can weigh down narrative rhythm. The appropriate test is not merely whether an idea recurs, but what consequence changes when it does. Here the actual bank deposits, Subhadra's written consent, the correction order for the leaflet and the documentary identification of Gunja's intermediary route all change the state of affairs. It would be wrong to call the sequence wholly static. Even so, later parvas must again test variation in the voices of characters and the construction of hearings.

Chapter 93 — The Connection Between Consignments

The Hospital Veranda: Two Timescales for Essential Service and Suspect Goods

The opening scene is arranged around three returned crates belonging to Madhav Rauniyar in the rear veranda of a hospital. Differences among their exterior pharmaceutical labels, interior distributor's seals and original distribution papers make the crates suspect, but do not establish "counterfeit drugs" without technical examination. Madhav will not sign for returned goods he has not inspected. Vibha Agrahari insists that patients receive medicine from approved stocks. These reactions embody two timescales within one crisis. Administrative time requires inspections, copies and laboratory tests; a patient's body cannot wait for today's medicine. The story refuses to place these demands in absolute opposition, holding the suspect materials for examination while continuing immediate services from approved supplies. An attendant's anonymised description of five patients' needs connects material evidence with saving lives, so that investigation does not appear to the reader as merely a paper-induced delay.

In the fifteenth segment a pharmacist acknowledges that the outer label did not correspond and distribution was therefore suspended. This separates the statement "labels do not match" from a claim about the medicine's quality or defect. Lack of proof that an object is lawful is not positive proof of its illegality. Madhav's three categories of cost—purchase, carriage and return—prevent his choice from becoming an abstract story of selfless charity: he incurs real loss, but refuses to charge patients for it. An elderly woman's demand for immediate medicine for her grandson tests the same ethical choice. She receives an explanation of the actual alternative means of obtaining medicine, not a hollow assurance. Compassionate rasa deepens through a specific mechanism of resource distribution rather than sentiment alone. The limitation is that the five patients do not receive individually differentiated medical scenes and remain a collective need.

Matching Numbers on Goods: Positive Evidence of Connection and Negative Limits on Crime

Rama's room is organised around three separate bags: the hospital's medicine documents, receipts for bundles of cloth belonging to Yusuf Ansari, and a police-sealed list of metal parts seized in connection with unauthorised weapons. Police have recorded recovery of the third crate in their initial written inspection, although its final technical classification

and provenance remain to be established. The story does not erase this real seizure; nor does it transform two other lawful business consignments into a single accusation merely by associating them with it. A common number at an intermediary booking counter, acknowledgment stamps and deposited fees point to an actual institutional relationship. Cart-driver Mahendra explains that the number identifies the booking counter, not ownership of a cart, and different employees may have worked different shifts there. The evidence may therefore suffice for the conclusion “shared counter,” but not for “shared criminal.”

The narrative questions of pakṣa, hetu and sādhya here take on something like laboratory discipline. If the proposition concerns institutional contact among three transport papers, the original ledger, receipt stamp, gate time and bank deposits may provide adequate grounds. But proving a single proprietor, common criminal intent or a unified violent instruction requires evidence of the person giving orders, identity of goods and particular control. Naira stops an assistant who infers common ownership because a metal crate and medicine crate have equal weight. An artisan's analogy compares a “five-seer hoe” with a sack of seeds of the same weight: equal quantity does not make objects identical. Applying this example to classical reasoning is the critic's reading; the character is not reciting a formal commentary on a Nyaya sutra.

In the eighteenth segment, sequential ledger pages, bank deposits and gate records from the same office jointly provide a level of confirmation that the intermediary booking system was used. Rama then removes a false assertion from a press statement: no evidence yet establishes that hospital medicines and weapons belong to “the same gang.” This goes beyond journalistic caution; the narrative forgoes a sensational solution to its own mystery. The adverse criticism is that the distinction between connection and guilt is explained over and over in different conversations, reducing independent interpretative space. Nevertheless, the practical value of caution is evident in what immediate suspicions do to the livelihoods of Yusuf, Harinarayan and Madhav.

One Window, Many Livelihoods: The Class Cost of Collective Suspicion

Harinarayan's ordinary hooks, axle nails and clamps used to hold a loom offer first-hand knowledge of what such tools are for. Inspectors earlier examined four of his tools without seizing any, and neither his seal nor his issue slip appears on the police crate. Yet Nandlal's failure to collect a ploughshare shows that documentary grounds for innocence do not restore customer trust automatically. Ajit's little rattle is spared becoming an exhibit in the public spectacle of the criminal mystery; he quietly takes

it back to his training work. This small resistance without speech, by father and son, moves the narrative beyond official debate to the enduring residue of humiliation.

Yusuf's first, lawful bolt of woven cloth has been released for sale. Examination continues of the second bundle tied with red cord and bearing an unauthorised acceptance strip. Declaring that "all Yusuf's goods were released" would falsify the social outcome. His debt for yarn and his mother's work at night reveal the material cost of delayed verification. Madhav's medicine returns constitute a separate dispute over expenses; Yusuf's craft products and the police seizure of weapons-related materials may enter the same plot network without being the same objects. The identical names Mahendra the cart-driver and Mahendra Mahaseth return the novel to the distinction between a name and a person. In response to a proposal to seize all of Mahaseth's customer records, certified copies limited to specified dates are agreed upon, balancing investigative power with commercial privacy. Binod's receipt from a small business does not implicate him but provides an independent check on the timing of use of the common office.

The narrative voice of this many-character design largely employs controlled external scenes in the third person. Naira helps divide information for the reader but is not an omniscient judge. Scenes move through the hospital, municipal room, cart-driver's ledger, loom, shop and the journey home. The principal action is compressed into one day from morning to night; older receipts, prior inspections and references to former events operate as analepses. The final exchange between Kabir and Naira prepares the birth question for the next chapter. The transition is structurally meaningful: "some truth about connection" has been found, but discovering a paper does not transfer ownership of another person's life-story to a journalist.

Achievement and an Opposing Conclusion

The chapter's verified advances are the common booking system's confirmed connection, correction of false wording accusing Mahaseth, written direction not to needlessly detain lawful consignments, technical testing of medicines with mismatched labels and an alternative source of approved drugs. The ultimate source of the weapons-related materials remains unknown; no single criminal organisation has been proved; Madhav has not received all the return costs; and Yusuf's second bundle has not been released. These incomplete outcomes give the narrative credible institutional time. The chapter is nevertheless crowded with different receipts, small commercial episodes and morally careful replies. A shared language of evidence risks suppressing the voices' inward diversity. Phenyl's smell at the hospital, a metal clamp, debt for yarn and the old woman's

urgent need for medicine help resist that tendency. Crime's mystery is situated within a world of labour; "The Connection Between Consignments" artfully interrupts the illicit passage from connecting objects to criminalising people.

Chapter 94 — The Rights of the Foster Parent

Direct Testimony of Birth and the Separate Truth of Lived Upbringing

"The Rights of the Foster Parent" begins in the courtyard of the mother who raised Kabir, where a stand for a lamp is measured. Instead of throwing away a cracked lamp, she saves it for flowers. This reuse is no grand symbolic proclamation but an act of household care, preservation and rearrangement. An old receipt for Kabir's school fees and the memory of his returning with a prize while feverish show that papers mark particular days but cannot equal the lived history of looking after him. Her memory of dates matters not only for accuracy but because of a child's sick body, household labour and worry. Without this framing, Subhadra's forthcoming words could become a theatrical substitution whereby the "real birth mother" suddenly displaces the mother who raised him.

In the presence of her four written conditions, Subhadra directly tells Kabir that she herself gave birth to him. This revelation actually occurs in the text and must not be weakened into a mere conjecture. Yet Subhadra specifies the limits of her testimony: her bodily experience supplies direct evidence to her, whereas whether a letter she sent was delivered, the roles of all involved, the official birth register and what the foster family was told belong to other domains of knowledge. Alongside "I know," she can say "I did not see." This self-imposed limit prevents the character from being a puzzle that merely conceals a criminal clue. She acknowledges ethical responsibility for her past without claiming to know every event.

Kabir does not immediately call her "Mother," and Subhadra does not demand that form of address. Hearing the truth and accepting a relationship unfold in different times. Living testimony changes his self-understanding but neither diminishes the love of his foster mother nor determines possible inheritance. Kabir says he will not voluntarily erase the name of the household that raised him from earlier records. Beyond emotional reassurance, the statement reserves a separate claim for future legal scrutiny. The novel establishes no definitive interpretation of any inheritance law through this scene; the wishes of the fostering household, older papers and applicable legal rights remain distinct matters for verification.

Two Kinds of First-Hand Knowledge in Documents: Limits on Both Mothers' Testimony

Subhadra takes from the cotton bag not the complete original of the earlier letter but a copy in which names and addresses are concealed. Its stained date and acknowledgment mark do not yet show that the letter

reached the right person. Kabir refrains from photographing it on his phone, recording instead the source details of the permitted portion for independent checking. This small action shows his development: a right to investigate birth history does not include a right to steal a private letter. Subhadra permits him to tell his foster family the birth information in his own words, but requires new consent for public circulation of a private copy. Rights relating to news, family conversation and the original document are separately bounded within a single agreement.

The foster mother recalls the day Kabir arrived, medical receipts from the first month and the history of a red-bordered handkerchief. She expressly acknowledges that she did not witness the birth. The mothers' accounts are not mutually destructive. Subhadra directly knows giving birth; the foster mother witnesses education, illness, work in the home and care through nights and days. Enlarging either witness's domain cannot erase the other's. This is an important reinterpretation of the novel's epic relation to Karna: modern Kabir's story recalls the nurturing relationship of Radha and Karna, but is not a reincarnation of the epic character. It involves a contemporary interpretation of rights. Karna's problems of publicly acknowledged parentage and social standing echo here, but the effects of Kabir's own legal documents cannot be inferred automatically from the Mahabharata.

Narrative time is distributed intriguingly. Memories spanning unspecified years enter present-day actions: a prize at school, a night drying a feverish child's notebook, the first month of his arrival and a difficult period in Subhadra's life. Analepsis arises through brief direct recollections and mentioned objects rather than fully reconstructed, elaborate scenes. Action pauses but emotional weight grows deeper. Readers do not obtain a complete answer to the birth question, yet Subhadra's truthful disclosure and Kabir's acceptance of the rights of his other home are genuine eventful advances. The lamp-and-flowers image at the close brings the broken lamp of the opening into new use. This circularity is not mere reassurance: Kabir still has questions, while a place remains open at home.

Vehicle Safety, Occupational Change and the Return of Goods: An Allied Ethic of Care for Livelihood

A brake inspection in Irfan Khan's vehicle workshop enters the chapter's middle. Worn bushings and unsafe brakes on a passenger vehicle are physically observed; a customer presses Irfan to release it after an oral “retest”; Irfan refuses in writing. These actions comprise a clear episode in occupational ethics. The pressure to get a sick person to hospital is real, but operating a dangerous vehicle under the name of service would increase

risk. Irfan does not accuse the earlier mechanic of intentionally creating the fault; he records what he has opened and inspected himself. An apprentice's wage entitlements reveal the cost of his decision. The narrative gives him no instant financial reward for honesty: the customer may take the job to another mechanic.

Salim, a traditional farrier, illustrates changes in hereditary work. Horseshoeing tools and a notebook from training in motor brakes lie in the same box: old skill is not simply destroyed but delimited and extended. Salim asks for written requirements covering training hours, safety, a stipend and examination of competence. Entering a new trade should not require indefinite unpaid apprenticeship. The uncertain, largely silent assent of his father and older relatives preserves the actual anxieties of working-class life. Here "fostering" has a parallel meaning beyond raising children: society must help sustain livelihoods by teaching sound ways to handle risk. That equivalence is a metaphor proposed by the critic; the novel does not explicitly advance a formal metaphysics of fostering.

Three bundles belonging to Harish Pansari bear prestigious exterior marks but conflicting interior descriptions, further broadening the issue to consumer rights. Harish stops selling the suspect stock, offers prior customers a refund or certified alternative, and pursues his own claim against the wholesaler separately. The prestige of a printed brand cannot establish the truth of the contents, but caution need not mean suspecting every buyer. Eight packets are actually returned, a modest proved outcome rather than a solution to the market's whole problem. Comparing a debtor's ledger with the mark of a packet provides a way for customers who lack formal bills to make legitimate claims. The narrative again holds protection of labour, life and evidence together.

The Strength of Narrative Form and the Awkward Questions

Kabir's inward change is measured in feeling rather than numbers of incidents. Subhadra's actual disclosure of birth, a personal conversation with the foster family, a folder separating rights and an arrangement of lamps that night make a concrete sequence of decisions. The limited third-person narrator stays close to Kabir's focalisation; Subhadra's own speech challenges him. The Irfan, Salim and Harish scenes can be understood as auxiliary ethical echoes of the central relationship. Yet three abruptly introduced occupational episodes can interrupt the emotional rhythm of Kabir's profoundly inward experience, and in places they do disperse concentration. The expansion is most persuasive where unsafe transport, training costs and refunds arise as concrete economic causes; if reduced to "proper boundaries everywhere," it risks argumentative repetition.

No final legal decision has been reached on Kabir's fostering rights; the original of Subhadra's letter remains unexamined; no inheritance entry has been newly made for the foster household; Irfan's vehicle has not been declared safe; and not all Harish's packets have been returned. But Subhadra has now directly spoken of birth, Kabir has heard her, and his foster mother has independently testified to the life of care. Those three established events make the dispute over names a humane yet complex social truth. "The Rights of the Foster Parent" is not an act of denying the birth mother; it proposes moving from competing entitlements towards a just coexistence governed by evidence and consent.

Chapter 95 — The Order to Kill

The Title of the Crime and the Jurisdiction of Evidence

The title “The Order to Kill” immediately leads the reader to expect a definite instruction to commit murder. The chapter, however, opens with two keys belonging to Shashi Mahuri, one to a spice warehouse and the other to a separately rented room. The keys indicate physical access to both spaces, not automatic proof of complicity in a crime. The tenant possessed limited rights to store goods; Shashi displays the agreement prohibiting subletting the room without permission, her earlier objection and its acknowledgment number. Ownership of premises, tenancy, actual use and control of entry are thus four separate positions. Possible use of the rear door, the watchman's night attendance and the nail holes left by a removed notice board open further material questions; the four holes do not establish the date when the board was removed. The narrative generates, then immediately checks, the reader's eagerness to identify a culprit.

Three folders on Rama's desk establish the chapter's evidentiary divisions: the assault and death of Mahesh, warehouse and transport records, and instructions issued from Devvrat's office. “Three folders” is not simply a means of sequencing material but separates jurisdictions of causal inquiry. The police treat Mahesh's murder as an established criminal event; investigation of the identity and role of the person who struck the blow remains incomplete. A note found at intermediary Shekhar's office reads, “Ensure the outcome that Mahesh's statement is stopped.” This is a dreadful indication of purpose, but it would contradict the source to describe it as Devvrat's signed, explicit order to kill. An instruction from Devvrat's office separately directs that material registers must not fall into unauthorised hands. Did an intermediary interpret that instruction as approval for violence, or was explicit violent authorisation given from above? Each possibility requires separate evidence.

Here the narrative can make disciplined use of analyses involving reason, general relation of inference and limiting condition. The simultaneity of “an instruction issued from an office” and “violence occurred” is not a necessary relation establishing assent to the crime. The language of the instruction, the recipient's interpretation, later oral contact, the real recipient of money and the power to decide upon the violent act are needed between the two. But caution must not become an excuse for dismissing Shekhar's night-entry permissions, pressure-related expenses, testimony about threats and telephone-message evidence as mere uncertainty. The novel presents not only an opposition between certain

and uncertain facts but the progressive accumulation of evidentiary weight.

"Night Pressure": Concentration of Evidence and the Need for Corroboration

A separate expense slip from Shekhar's office records two instalments and an item labelled "night pressure." Its figures match bank withdrawals, although full confirmation of the recipient account is pending. The dates fall near the first assault on Mahesh and the subsequent fatal attack. Such proximity increases suspicion without settling the outcome. Wire and a receipt marked "rear door" are found in the warehouse's back room, but the wire is not declared the murder weapon. A former driver offers direct auditory testimony that he heard Shekhar threaten to prevent Mahesh from surviving to give a statement; meanwhile the time, continuity and speaker identity of a recorded voice message require independent technical verification. The evidentiary forms are layered: the driver's "I heard" claims direct hearing; the recording is a technical acoustic object; identifying Shekhar as its speaker is another inference.

In the next segment, Shekhar's approval of night movements by two people through the rear warehouse, gate times and a chain of payments reinforce one another. At this point the prior defensive story that Shekhar was merely an ineffectual clerk grows weaker: his actual role in night operations becomes a concrete subject of inquiry. Nevertheless, two faces have not been conclusively identified in the video, and the person who struck at the murder scene is still unknown. The text remains deliberately difficult: evidence of unusual arrangements grows denser, while proof of intention and of the ultimate actor remains incomplete. Ethical responsibility to truth here means not merely denunciation of the accused but constructing procedures capable of supporting a lasting conviction. Rama does not treat Shekhar's request to give a statement with his lawyer present as an admission of guilt. Protecting procedural rights amid incomplete evidence is not an obstacle to investigation but a condition of its credibility.

An important counterargument is that the story's evidence arrives in remarkably orderly categories: expense slips, bank withdrawals, gate attendance, night access, the driver's statement, digital files. The network shows skill in narrative construction, but the characters state the limits of every stage with almost exemplary neatness. How deeply actual investigations are complicated by mistakes, conflicts of interest and partisanship must be examined in later chapters. The narrator's smooth classification does not itself secure a just outcome. Even so, refusing to

declare Shekhar immediately guilty makes the story more responsible, not weaker.

Mahesh's Wife and Daughter: The Right to Grieve and the Rejection of Unnecessary Testimony

On entering the interview room, Mahesh's wife first asks who will protect the space outside her home and how her daughter is to travel to school. News of the murder investigation is not merely a case for her: it concerns the safety of the next day's ordinary routine. An attack occurred even after earlier assurances, so she now demands a written schedule naming the personnel who will actually provide protection and an emergency contact. She reports only what she personally heard in her last conversation with her husband, explicitly saying that she never heard Mahesh say, "Devvrat will have me killed." She refuses to let her widowhood become a means of falsely corroborating somebody else's allegation. At this point the firmness of a woman's voice gains an ethical force beyond its place in a court record.

The daughter's question—"Have they caught the people who frightened him?"—and the mother's answer produce a powerful distinction between delayed justice and the finality of death. A conviction must await proof; the fact that her father will never return requires no waiting. The child then completes an unfinished mathematics problem. Compassionate rasa arises not only from the death in the story but from the immutable loss beside the continuing necessity of learning ordinary mathematics. The catastrophe of drama and the persistence of daily life coexist in one segment. When Naira gives the wife a draft news report, the woman asks only that the present directions to her home and her daughter's school identity be removed. This is not general editorial approval of the entire article but limited consent for private safety. The story respects the victim's rights without making her an all-knowing witness to the crime.

Surnames, the Prestige of Charity and Obstacles to Separate Livelihoods

Someone used Shabnam Malik's family name to request permission to access a file in a service office. Shabnam objects in writing as a person who never made the application; an employee had inferred administrative authority from the prestigious surname. The accusation is not that Shabnam is a criminal. The established error is that access was granted without the individual's written authorisation. The public correction records the type of mistake, while the questions of who saw which document and whether anything was removed remain for a separate inquiry. This smaller incident restores the previous Karna Parva question

of similarity of names in an institutional form: a family name may signify power but does not adequately establish either legal consent or personal identity.

Devvrat's relief fund did actually pay for Jamuna's medicines and vehicle fare. Aniruddha acknowledges the genuine benefit of treatment without allowing charity to close investigative questions. The narrative does not reject philanthropy wholesale; it keeps accounts for public assistance, control of materials and possible indications of violence distinct. Warehouse owner Shashi likewise refuses to make her spice workers bear the entire burden of a tenant's possible crime. While the rented room is under investigation, access is preserved for removing goods from other secure storerooms, and Shashi separately settles four days' wages owed to Parvati. Rigour in handling evidence is not made the sole means by which a worker's livelihood must be destroyed.

The final journalistic edit reflects upon the chapter's title. Naira initially writes, "Murder order exposed," then chooses the more evidence-sensitive "Three Questions About the Murder Order." This self-correction stages editorial ethics within the work. The editor's practical challenge—who will read such a complicated headline?—is nevertheless valid: how can precise information also be accessible to the public? The chapter ends not as a substitute for a complete legal investigation but by insisting upon responsible public narration. The final sealed page is not Sarita's private original list of twenty-seven names, but a copy of an older payment schedule. The partial agreement of an acknowledgment number requires separate inquiry. The principal murder investigation is not made into the final definition of the lives of all twenty-seven people.

Achievement, Limitation and the Chapter's Determination

Mahesh's murder is established in Chapter 95; the weight of evidence concerning Shekhar's intermediary arrangements grows; no explicit written murder order from Devvrat is available; and investigation of other oral contacts and decisive roles remains pending. Security arrangements, personal permissions and measures protecting livelihoods have been recorded at certain levels, but the family's fear has not vanished. Narrative time extends from the dawn warehouse to the night's news, incorporating analepses involving earlier attacks and records of death. Inferences that arise in Naira's mind are constrained by Rama's distinct administrative language and the bodily present of Mahesh's wife. Poetically, the ring of keys, a white rectangle on the upright wall and the daughter's completed mathematics problem ground the story in human life. The weak point is the recurrence of densely procedural investigative dialogue, which sometimes submerges the fear of crime in the language of office folders. But from the perspective of Mahesh's family, the possibility of an "order"

matters as much as their safety on the following day. The tension between those concerns constitutes the chapter's real literary achievement.

Chapter 96 — Reconciling the Twenty-Seven

The Brass Box and Three Tables: Controlled Verification, Not a Final Revelation

Before opening the brass box, Sarita wipes away dust. Drops of post-rain water at the doorway, the steam of rice in the house and Sanket's books recall the domestic space-time of the novel's opening. In the first chapter there was the contradiction between Sarita's death notice and her kitchen; here she herself sets the conditions for using her papers. Sanket is not appointed guardian of the documents but sent to school. This decision marks an important intergenerational limit: resistance to institutional injustice does not justify destroying a child's life of learning. The novel avoids turning the brass box into a symbol of fabulous hidden treasure. It makes the box a centre of household privacy, preservation of documents and ownership of decisions.

In the municipal records room Rama sets three tables apart: Sarita's personally handwritten list; government copies and payment schedules; and consents and verification results. This spatial arrangement establishes three forms of authority. Sarita's "original" is the original of her own handwriting, not the government's original entry—an explanation she makes herself. Four inks and repeated revisions do not prove the whole account was invented on a single night, but neither do they establish an exact date. Authenticity demands a coordinated but cautious comparison of the object's date, the writer's recollection and the sources of official copies. Sarita's pages mingle matters she saw herself, things she heard and things she wrote as her own inferences; she acknowledges the mixture. Rather than diminishing her testimony, this renounces a claim to omniscience.

It is crucial to keep the meaning of "reconciliation" fixed in this chapter. The relationships among twenty-seven necessary entries, available testimony and the status of available transactions have been checked. That alone is a definite narrative result. The secrets of twenty-seven entire lives have not thereby been revealed; all arrears have not been paid; all incorrect official statuses have not been corrected; and not everyone's true former name has been published. Indeed, the identity in one of the twenty-seven lines is verified through a representative chosen by the person concerned, in the limited presence of Rama and Sarita. Naira voluntarily leaves the room. This reverses the conventional expectation that a story's central mystery should culminate in revelation: the reader can trust that the numerical reconciliation is complete without receiving a private name at

the cost of someone's safety. The limit on information arises not from authorial incapacity but from permission determined by a character.

Rahina's Testimony: The Labour of Transcription, Family Pressure and Remaining Blanks

Rahina Thakurai enters as an independent centre of the chapter. Her fingers are stained blue with ink from copying; she served rice at home at dawn, attended to responsibilities towards her daughter, and then came out for the office investigation. A paternal cousin warns that the family's name may be tarnished; Rahina does not accept this argument as an automatic bar to truth. She insists on giving her statement on time because her wage-earning work that evening is at risk. A woman's voice here is not merely an assertion of rights: it is a decision about labour, expressed with the cost of time in view. Distinguishing the authority of family "honour" from that of a woman's "copy directly seen" is particularly significant for Videha's parallel-history perspective on overlooked women copyists.

Rahina brings a wage receipt from copying work done three years earlier. In five lines her copy bore markers for amendments to identity in place of names, and beside one line a warning, "Do not publish"; those words were absent from a later printed copy. She does not, however, know whether someone intentionally erased them. Office receipt numbers and a correspondence of times confirm her copying work, while the column for the original order is empty. Truthfulness in testimony appears in the ability to specify a blank, rather than imagine how it should be filled. Rahina allows her name and her work on the copy she saw to be published; she does not consent to disclosure of her daughter's school or the identity of men in her household. A woman's public voice and her household's entitlement to private safety are not opposed.

Someone had interpreted Sarita's two words "returned" as meaning returned to employment; the woman concerned explains that she had appeared at the relief office for a second time after the flood. Her objection corrects an official's hasty conclusion that "the first claim is cancelled." The meaning of words in the original line cannot be final without the witness's experience. This is suitable for modern discussion of verbal cognition and intended meaning in the Tattvacintāmaṇi tradition, though we must not invent a statement from any specific aphorism in the classical treatise. Ambiguity in a single written phrase may alter the sequence of two entitlements to payment. A zero amount means not "no work" but "no payment recorded in this register." Accordingly, when constructing social history, we must not take the silence of a government ledger as proof that people were inactive.

Illegitimate Addition of Numbers and the Continuing Limits of Fourteen Separate Disputes

A clerk tries to make twenty-seven by adding five changed identities, fourteen discrepancies and eight death-related cases. Rama refuses. This test of numbers is crucial: the three groups concern different systems of records; some people may figure in more than one dispute, while some may not appear in the original twenty-seven lines at all. Although 5 + 14 + 8 = 27 is an arithmetically correct statement, “the same twenty-seven people” does not follow from it. Identifying the persons within the groups is necessary for specifying the subject of a narrative claim; equality in the sizes of groups is not equality of their attributes. The novel thus deliberately blocks an easy mathematical decoding of its previously complex events.

A match between an acknowledgment number in the murder inquiry involving Shekhar's intermediary and a number in the old payment schedule does not establish “the same transaction.” One original ledger records a fee for transporting bundles, another a charge for inspecting a copied booklet; dates and amounts differ. Similar numerical formats may be products of office procedure. The relation between Giridhari's two confirmed instalments and Sarita's withheld transcription pay also requires full comparison with the original delivery pages. Successful formal reconciliation does not automatically pay her arrears. In this web of contextual relations, the questions of credit and entitlement beginning with “Radha's Labour,” the personal handwriting of “The Original Page,” “Five Changed Identities,” “Fourteen Discrepancies,” “Four Alive, Four Dead,” “A Convenient Error” and “The Order to Kill” touch one another without being dissolved into one plot.

Sumitra Kami's original design for a metal joint and the blank space for “maker” in a new contract bring the chapter into the ethics of craftsmanship. An ordinary right angle is nobody's private property; a specific groove measurement, prototype tests, preparation of the design and credit for training constitute separate claims. The new joint has been withheld from use pending technical safety tests, but Sumitra's claim to be named is immediately entered in the record, while remuneration awaits a separate hearing. Sumitra does not claim Chhotelal's wages for grinding the metal under her own name. The scene carries Karna Parva from debates over inherited names towards real ownership of productive labour. A short exchange between Rahina and Sumitra creates an archival parallel between the ink of transcription and the grooves cut in iron, without effacing the particular markets in which these occupations operate.

Narrative Time, the Private Reader and the Unfinished Future of the Ending

The day-long procedure of "Reconciling the Twenty-Seven" begins with rice in a home, extends across three tables in the records room, and contracts again into a domestic hearth and the night's lines of news. Focalisation moves among Sarita, Rama and Naira. Naira's uncertain desire for information is disciplined by Sarita's permission and Rama's institutional responsibilities. Naira's actual departure during the limited verification of the twenty-seventh person's identity is a negative event of focalisation: although the reader remains within the range of the narrator's available camera, information is withheld because the scene has been ethically closed. This formal literary choice gives effect to a character's privacy at the very level of narration.

This form has limitations too. The principal act of reconciling the list is reduced to a succession of written conclusions and ethical cautions; the individual voices of many among the twenty-seven do not reach the reader. To make the complete reconciliation credible, the writer relies heavily on the procedural integrity of the characters. Readerly curiosity about the particular outcomes in the complex lives of certain unknown individuals remains unsatisfied. But incompleteness and possible narrative weakness are not identical: the desire of the reader to know and the right of the person to grant permission are the chapter's fundamental ethical conflict. What will be necessary in later parvas is to show the relevant social consequences of the evidence held in confidence; otherwise repeated prescriptions of "separate inquiry" may become a repetitive substitute for emotional narrative progress.

At the end, Aniruddha's crises over medicines, vehicles and drainage at the hospital; Sumitra's demand to stop unsafe gate work; Sarita's still unimplemented correction of her death status; the pending investigation concerning Shekhar and Devvrat; and the separate search for Mithun all demonstrate that reconciliation of one list does not eliminate the contradictions of the social world. Sarita takes her original brass-box list home; sealed findings from the inspection remain in the office. The two locations of these objects protect distinct jurisdictions of knowledge and authority. The pot of rice is once more over the fire; Sanket returns from school and writes difficult words; Kabir brings a note for a wooden shelf. Domestic routine again proves larger than either triumph or defeat on government paper. The definite conclusion is only this: the required relationships among twenty-seven entries have been reconciled, and private names have not been publicly disclosed without individual consent. To call it the final answer to all 216 chapters, or complete justice, would be wrong.

Karna Parva / Sundara Kanda: Overall Critical Assessment of Chapters 85–96

The twelve chapters of Karna Parva travel through six inner strands: birth, upbringing, credit, social identity, official entries and criminal investigation. Chapters 85–88 introduce Radha's labour in raising Karna, Sarita's original private page, five altered identities and fourteen administrative discrepancies. Chapters 89–92 develop erroneous death marks against four living people, active accounts of four deceased people, Subhadra's conditions of testimony, Sarita's outstanding wages and the refutation of the charge against Janki. Chapters 93–96 reach a real intermediary connection among consignments, the separate truths of the birth mother and foster mother, layers of evidence in the investigation of Mahesh's murder, and the limited reconciliation of twenty-seven entries. This sequence is not a simplified unveiling of one grand "conspiracy," but a system of evidence with differing consequences for numerous lives. The parva's stated 31,783 word units measure the extent of text; they are not an index of actual event density.

The Mahabharata's conflict over Karna's birth, upbringing and social recognition is reflected in the dialogue among the modern Kabir, Subhadra and the woman who raised him. But contemporary characters decide what recognition and inheritance may follow disclosure of a birth secret in accordance with their present relationships and documentary rights. Mechanically equating any modern character with the mythic role of Kunti or Radha would violate the novel's multi-temporal form. Its dialogue with the Ramayana's Sundara Kanda concerns the ethics of "carrying a message" and "returning with reliable evidence"; not every modern consignment, letter, folder or messenger can be treated as a direct incarnation of Hanuman. The relation to three philosophical traditions should be accepted only where the novel's paratext makes it explicit. Analysis through evidentiary categories is the critic's instrument of inquiry, not a reason to turn every character's behaviour into a direct quotation from the treatises.

In its treatment of narrative time, the parva develops largely through collisions between brief ordinary days, from dawn to night, and records extending many years into the past. The attention to objects—the brass box, memories of Karna's upbringing, differently coloured slips, medicine crates, warehouse keys, seals, bank deposits and the original metal-joint design—turns things into tangible witnesses of story-time. Sarita's everyday kitchen is a stable point of reference for social neglect and self-assertion; the stand and lamp in Kabir's mother's home preserve an ineffable private relationship. Alternating the focalisation among

characters provides social breadth, but significant emotional centres may be submerged beneath the crowd of vocational subplots.

The clearest achievement of Karna Parva is distinguishing types of conclusion. The grounds of the earlier accusation against Janki have been disproved, but Mithun has not therefore been found. Subhadra has directly testified that she gave birth to Kabir, but this does not automatically complete proof through the official birth register. Several links involving Shekhar's pressure and night access have emerged, but they do not establish that Devvrat ordered the murder. Twenty-seven entries have been reconciled, but this has not corrected every payment. From the standpoint of social and ethical criticism, this is a demanding literary effort to keep justice proportionate to knowledge. Its shortcomings must also be seen: similar divisions of evidence recur in characters' dialogue, sometimes reducing competing dramatic desires to the same vocabulary of legal caution, while the administrative consequences of social pressure are repeatedly deferred to "the next hearing." Future evaluation must test how effectively these delays bear fruit in the later parvas dealing with disaster, death, justice and rehabilitation.

The decisive incompleteness of Chapters 85–96 does not make them less consequential. Karna Parva moves from the private truth of birth to collective justice concerning records without treating personal privacy as an enemy of truth. An official acknowledgment seal on a list, a mother's confidential testimony, an artisan's design made by her own hands and the limited consent of a murdered man's widow are distinct places from which justice can be understood. By giving these sites equal dignity, the novel develops an ethical possibility for a modern epic. Whether this possibility achieves full artistic success should be judged not from Karna Parva alone, but from the outcomes in the subsequent Shalya, Sauptika and Stri Parvas and the Uttara Kanda.

Chapter 97 — Shalya's Loyalty

The Disguise of Hospitality-Debt: The Origin of a Promise and Freedom of Choice

The chapter opens with a chariot in ancient Madra. Shalya is not merely a warrior of noble lineage; he commands a contingent sustained by the labour of horse attendants, cooks, grain-cart drivers and foot soldiers. Leather swollen by the night's dew, oil on the axle, and the exhausted bodies of servants appear before any political proclamation of war. The critical significance of this sequence is that the narrative immediately makes visible whose bodies will bear the consequences of a king's promise. Seeing the magnificence of the welcome, an elderly attendant assumes that

Yudhishthira is its patron, but the host does not disclose his identity. Shalya then promises to meet a reasonable request from the unnamed 'giver of hospitality', whereupon Duryodhana appears before him. The fundamental narrative snare lies in this deferred disclosure of the name, not merely in the production of a last-minute surprise.

Shalya tells Duryodhana plainly that a debt for a meal and choosing a side in battle through deceit are not the same thing. Nevertheless, he does not declare his promise entirely void: acknowledging his share in the decision, he changes his military allegiance. This is a morally difficult conjunction. The deception was indeed the host's, but the responsibility for joining the opposing side belongs to Shalya himself. The episode of sending separate letters to his nephews Nakula and Sahadeva places an admission at the centre of his self-criticism: describing himself as 'compelled' would conceal his own choice. The character is not transformed into an immaculate emblem of resistance; the question of participation in a culpable structure remains alongside the question of loyalty.

In the language of narrative evidence, 'hospitality was provided' concerns a directly occurring event; 'because of that hospitality all the soldiers voluntarily joined the war' is a separate proposition to be established. The acknowledgement of food received was made collectively under the commander's seal; it need not amount to the individual consent of each soldier. Thus the imagined universal relation between hospitality and military assent is qualified by a restricting condition, an upādhi. Shalya's demand for the expense ledger is not a decorative philosophical gesture but a material test of the claim to collective willingness. Counting separately the grain brought from Madra and the food offered in welcome establishes a distinction between changing political allegiance and transferring ownership of property. The text does not, however, tell us how far the servants subsequently received institutional means of making independent decisions. Their dependence on the king's discernment remains a limitation of the scene.

Five Objects in the Hospital and One Patient's Actual Route

The modern temporal strand enters not in the twenty-third but in the thirteenth textual segment, with a hospital scene at dawn. Aniruddha sees a damaged stretcher wheel and a cracked floor: even after the reconciliation of the twenty-seven entries, the floor has not been repaired. This juxtaposition immediately places material incompletion beside the archival achievement of the preceding parva. At the hospital gate, Tara and Hira distinguish the zero points of two water gauges: the official measurement and the village's older mark cannot be equated without checking. Immediate access for a patient and permanent drainage are separate questions. Five objects are placed on the table: the warehouse key

box, the vehicle slip, a copy of the water-gauge record, the kitchen expense ledger and the rules for the public copy. Their conjunction constitutes the narrative 'assembly' of the chapter. The crises of all parties touch one another, yet each requires different evidence and a different authority.

The first agreement had broken down over 'unrestricted entry through the private field bund'. A new official wants to write 'unanimously agreed facility' into the proposal, but Shabnam reminds him that the meeting has not yet reached a decision. The distinction between information, proposal and actual consent becomes sharper through the objections of Rama Karna and Ramesh's wife. The latter is not obstructing the patient: she raises the question of compensation for damage after an unauthorised cut through privately cultivated land. Her labour-marked palm is more than descriptive detail. Measurement of water flow and the possible destruction of seeds in the field become two distinct kinds of direct experience at the same place.

Ruhani separates the costs of grain, fuel, washing utensils, transport and special meals. Voluntarily sending two vessels of rice is not the same as operating a free daily kitchen for fifty people. Sumitra's new metal prototype, although her own design, is untested for medical use; Irfan refuses to call a defective axle safe merely because a new wheel has been fitted. In this scene the author blocks possible fallacies arising from 'good intentions': generosity, ownership of craftsmanship and urgency do not, by themselves, establish safety.

In the twenty-fourth textual segment, Jagdish Jha's daughter-in-law speaks for herself concerning her treatment, the confidentiality of her name and her choice of a checked route. A successful transfer is carried out by four bearers—two workers from the river landing and two trained assistants—without cutting through the private bund. The significance of this single event is concrete, but its limits are equally clear: the rates for the four bearers have been recorded, yet neither the entire road, the drain nor the warehouse's medicine crisis has been resolved. Finally Shabnam has 'unanimous' struck out and 'disputed proposal' written instead; Hira's signature remains confined to one inspected stretch of footpath. Naira's revised headline, 'A Route Opened for One Patient; Five Conditions Still Under Examination', constitutes a correction of the news narrator's own overextended conclusion. This subtle self-revision enters into a dialogue of meaning with responsibility for one's promise in the opening Shalya scene.

Narrative Time, Focalisation and the Limits of Achievement

The ancient story runs from rest at night to the morning decision about allegiance. The modern sequence moves from a damaged wheel at dawn through a midday meeting, the transfer of one patient and an evening

correction of a headline. The two periods are independent scenes: there is neither reincarnation of a character nor a corresponding genealogical line. Shalya's inward hesitation is disclosed through an omniscient narrator; in the modern portion, the voices of Naira, Tara, Ruhani, Ramesh's wife and the patient distribute the centres of focalisation among the characters. When this polycentric narration arrives at documents of inspection, however, an individual's consciousness is sometimes submerged under institutional description.

The chapter's finest achievement is to connect 'the limits of a promise' with scenes, meals, expense books, measurements, signatures and the actual carrying of a human body. The critical objection is that almost every participant in the hospital meeting speaks in a language that precisely distinguishes kinds of evidence. Consequently, some utterances sound more like polished legal arguments than expressions of uncertainty under real pressure. The passage of a single patient across a broken river route and past a closed warehouse provides an emotional centre; nevertheless, the repeated explanation of conditions around this event can slow the natural pace of suspense.

Chapter 98 — Vibhishana's Path

Dissent Within the Kingdom: Brotherhood, Refuge and Household Labour

The ancient Lanka sequence opens with a water pot and a child's question: 'Who will say that we are safe?' Before the frenzy of war, the narrative attends to the safe movement of families and the diminishing rice supplies of servants. The source of the guard's reported threat that the royal treasury will be closed is unverified; nevertheless, the fear generated within the household by the threat as heard is real. This is not merely a defect of verbal testimony but a poetics of the narrative production of social fear. Vibhishana opposes Sita's forcible confinement in the royal council under his own name, without disclosing the name of an anonymous soldier. Asking an officer for the source of his supposedly certain enemy numbers and demanding that Ravana answer concerning a woman's consent reinforce one another: unsupported military information and an unproved royal justification are both challenged.

Vibhishana's wife identifies an important limitation in his own understanding. He has decided to leave home, but he does not fully control the consequences for his wife, child and servants. She insists upon her rights in deciding whether the family will stay and who will fill the household water pots. Leaving the original wage register with the family and taking only the papers needed for travel divides his responsibilities

appropriately. He does not sell Lanka's confidential routes or the names of innocent servants as the price of receiving asylum. This is where the rereading of the epic 'change of sides' becomes particularly significant: public speech is evidence of ethical dissent, but it does not confer a right to make another person's private information public.

In Rama's camp, Sugriva and other members of the army express suspicion. Rama grants refuge for the protection of life but distinguishes the right to asylum from access to confidential military plans. Vibhishana separates what he has seen from what he has heard about Sita's location; he does not demand that the camp treat his loyalty as already proved. Here 'refuge' is an ethical arrangement of immediate protection, not a 'complete certificate of trust'. This remains, however, a contemporary imaginative interpretation of the Ramayana: criticism ought not to present it as a verbatim rendering of the ancient source.

The Drivers' Strike: Not the Suspension of Rights, but Limited Lifesaving Assistance

The modern section begins in Videhapur in 2039, with Tulsi checking vehicles at the hospital's back gate. The drivers are on strike over three months of unpaid risk allowances, night journeys and the burden of repairing an unsafe culvert. To regard their strike solely as 'self-interest opposed to service' would distort the actual facts of the original text. There is a real need to transfer hospital patients, but their number is uncertain and their medical conditions differ; Aniruddha therefore specifies the certified emergency requests separately. Hira and Tara's water measurements do not yet establish that the route can bear heavy vehicles. Ramesh's wife grants permission to take measurements, not to enter her private field bund.

Paro, a woman driver, presents the unpaid amounts for two medical trips made at night: the additional payment had been entered under a freight carrier's account. Her statement reveals the actual structure of wages, beyond a general fear of accidents. Finding a defect in the brakes, Irfan prohibits a long journey; trained staff will examine whether a smaller vehicle in sound condition can accommodate a stretcher. Ruhani distinguishes voluntary food donations from payment to cooks. By drawing together different spheres of labour, the work makes 'disaster' not a single-strand tale of heroism but a network of mutual dependence and separately payable dues.

Tulsi's three written conditions—only certified patients or approved lifesaving consignments; an agreed driver, a safe vehicle and payment; and separate consent for the use of private land—produce a limited trial plan for the following day, from six in the morning until noon. Two drivers

refuse and three agree; a subsequent inspection finds one of the vehicles unsuitable, leaving only two available. The numerical sequence matters. 'Three drivers agreed' and 'three vehicles will operate' are not identical statements. At the end the strike continues, while limited transport is available for patients; earlier arrears, the warehouse seal and the obstruction of the main drain remain. Naira crosses out her incorrect headline, 'Strike Broken', and corrects it. Through this scene the novel makes the ethics of reporting an active part of its narrative action.

Evidence, Temporal Flow and the Critical Counterposition

The ancient temporal strand follows a clear sequence from household to council, expulsion, seashore and refuge. The modern strand forms a bounded administrative day and night, from the morning vehicle inspection to the list prepared the following dawn. In ancient time Vibhishana's conflict of character is shown from within; in the modern section the statements of Tulsi, Jamir, Paro, Ramesh's wife and Aniruddha arise out of different immediate interests. The resemblance between 'asylum' and a 'safe emergency exception' operates at the level of questioning loyalty, not of identical characters or historical causation.

Narratologically, 'seeing a receipt slip' does not by itself establish that payment was made; a 'survey map' is not permission for private entry; and 'a vehicle is available' does not establish its medical suitability for transferring a patient elsewhere. Material evidence clarifies the limits of these exceptions in the story. Its literary achievement lies in showing that refuge is an act of compassion, but compassion need not require the removal of others' rights. Its limitation is that the modern meeting gradually becomes a series of written subclauses. Many participants speak in impeccably theoretical terms, so the inner fear, anger and unequal bargaining power of a precarious strike are sometimes less apparent. The small closing scene of Tulsi's daughter and a broken umbrella returns this formal sequence to domestic time.

Chapter 99 — Kumbhakarna's Awakening

From Sleep to War: Participation Despite Knowing the Cause to Be Wrong

The first sign of Kumbhakarna's awakening is not a roar but a cough. Blisters on the female attendant's hands, the smoke of torches, weary servants and a half-empty water pot place the renowned body of the mighty warrior within a network of bodies on which his care depends. His insistence that those who awakened him should be fed before he himself eats brings the ethics of household labour before royal valour. An elderly

attendant's question, 'Will we now be able to sleep?', returns at the end, bringing the immense time of a great war into collision with the time labourers need for rest.

Kumbhakarna refuses to accept a report that calls Vibhishana a 'traitor to his brother'; he asks separately about the sources concerning Sita's imprisonment, the dispute in council and Vibhishana's own statement. Mandodari supplies an incomplete list of injured households: where access to a home has been blocked, information about it is missing. Kumbhakarna does not turn that absence into proof that 'no one lives there'. His instruction to the commander who has erased small villages from a war map to verify the existence of their inhabitants marks a grave distinction between an empty space on a map and the absence of human life.

Kumbhakarna tells Ravana unequivocally that holding Sita without her consent is unjust. Nevertheless, he decides to go to war to protect the city's vulnerable inhabitants, imposing upon himself a prohibition against attacking the wounded, the disarmed and civilians. His choice differs from both Shalya's and Vibhishana's. Despite being deceived by a debt of hospitality, Shalya changes sides; Vibhishana leaves the royal house because of its injustice; Kumbhakarna recognises the cause as wrong yet joins the kingdom's military campaign. The text gives no guarantee that his declaration of ethical restraint will prevent actual violence in war. Its achievement is to avoid declaring participation in an unjust war innocent merely because its participant invokes a 'defensive purpose'.

Kamlesh's Repair and Devi's Training: Two Independent Forms of Agency

The modern section begins in a rain-soaked lane of Videhapur in 2039, at the repair shop of Kamlesh Dabgar. Presented with a new notice demanding three times the rent or that he vacate within seven days, Kamlesh refuses to sign immediately. He prepares separate accounts for rent, repairs, customers' outstanding debts and his private property. A date comparison substantiates the impropriety of an attempt to collect a fee for a proposed municipal drain repair on the community platform as though it were already complete. But neither the original private rent nor the dispute over the landlord's rights has been finally decided. This is an explicit presentation of the limits of evidence: one basis for a false charge has collapsed, but the entire tenancy dispute has not been won.

Devi Gond's training register marks her 'absent' for three shifts. She possesses bus-fare receipts, training attendance records and hospital supply-receipt numbers. An officer cites her mother's illness as a reason for leaving training, though there is neither a medical order nor a valid basis for

ending the programme. At home her mother raises the real problem of receiving medicine on time; the narrative does not dissolve that practical need into a mere declaration of 'women's freedom'. Devi, her mother and her brother devise a schedule of paid caregiving, while the mother retains the right to keep her own prescription. Elsewhere, under Salma's supervision, Devi counts seventeen bandages where eighteen are expected, and records the shortage rather than writing a false total in the name of emergency. Asking for a patient's consent during training and treating a red mark for error as evidence of learning create positive scenes of character development.

Kamlesh and Devi do not belong within one identical framework of propriety. Kamlesh's predicament forms a triangle of private rent, public passage and ownership of craftsmanship; Devi's forms another triangle of training, care at home and patient consent. When the temporary use of a plank from Kamlesh's shop for hospital drainage is proposed, there is agreement in principle about measurement, time and remuneration, not permanent dispossession. Reconsideration of the three incorrectly recorded absences in Devi's training is accepted; a corrected register or payment of the training allowance has yet to follow. The story maintains a measured proportion between minor successes and major matters left undecided.

The Leaking Pot: The Meaning of the Metaphor and Its Artistic Risks

The closing scene tests Kamlesh's half-repaired water pot by filling it. A single drop leaks, so he does not hand the pot to the customer, but examines it again. This is not simply a verbal symbol of 'unfinished reform'; it is an internal standard of the skill of repair. The amount already mended is visible, and what remains defective can also be held in the hand. A mother's question about the difference between a red mark at school meaning 'removal of a name' and one signifying 'an error from which to learn' enters into dialogue with this evidence-bearing symbol. The drainage water is still blocked; the small leak in a pot does not resolve the public obstruction by reducing it to a facile metaphor.

A question of artistic limitation remains. The ancient descriptions of Kumbhakarna's attendant, Mandodari, the departure for war and soldiers' families open out an expansive ethical rereading, but many subordinate clauses appear arranged in the style of modern 'safety administration'. In the modern section, the precise separation of Kamlesh's and Devi's accounts is an achievement, yet it somewhat slows the energy of classical conflict. Even so, the acceptance of responsibility for going to war and the retesting of the unfinished pot prevent the reader from resting in 'the success of action' and bring them instead to 'accountability for action'.

This semantic turn is important in the work's passage from Karna Parva to Shalya Parva.

Chapter 100 — The Second Agreement

The Record of the First Failed Accord That a New Page Cannot Erase

The chapter opens not with an independent ancient scene but with five wet sheets of paper in the municipal office at dawn. Urmila copies the blurred times again from the original register. The opening is sensuous—a dripping roof, an empty earthen cup once used for curd, sticky leaves—but its narrative function is to preserve the original information. Rama will not permit the objection sheet from the first failed meeting to be torn up. A new agreement may answer an earlier dispute; it cannot abolish that history. Naira's opening note, 'Second meeting; first objection preserved', exemplifies an editorial discipline within narration itself.

Devvrat wants to count an office assistance payment as an achievement of the new accord; Aniruddha distinguishes the separate aid receipt from responsibility for the patient's actual route. This is not the deletion of an entry but the delimitation of its context. The first vehicle draft vaguely promises that a vehicle will be 'available when needed'; Jamir asks who will determine the need, how many vehicles there will be and where drivers will rest. The final proposal specifies certified medical demand, actually available safe vehicles, consenting drivers, the recorded time of delay, risk allowances and a separate register of arrears. Thus the wording defines the conditions in which a service can be provided; it does not guarantee vehicles for all time.

Drains, Warehouse, Kitchen and Copies: Different Evidence for Five Conditions

Under the second condition, an engineer wishes to obtain cheaper drainage by cutting through a private field bund. Ramesh's wife asks about the cost to her cultivated land and the basis of permission; the engineer has no written authority for emergency entry. It is possible to measure the removal of a small obstruction within the public drain, but structural repair of the main wall remains outstanding. Paro, a stonecutter, agrees to cut stone but holds the engineer responsible for certifying the load-bearing capacity of the underlying soil. Her contract recognises her right to stop work if a safety objection is recorded. This is not an abstract pronouncement about rights: it is a living worker's decision to refuse responsibility for work whose load-bearing conditions have not been established.

The third condition concerns two warehouse lists: approved treatment supplies and a consignment held because of inconsistent labels. Rama strikes out a proposal to release both with a single 'disaster clearance' stamp. A workers' representative adds an inventory of the contents, resealing and the payment category. This small detail is also a precaution against conflating the principal plot of the investigation into Mahesh's murder with the warehouse issue. Devvrat's signature on the new agreement does not establish his innocence in the earlier inquiry into violence; nor is his silence taken as a confession.

The fourth condition is measured through Ruhani's two containers—rice cooked today and uncooked lentils. Grain donations, purchases and wages become three separate columns. The objection that no family has consented to the public photography of its meal brings the narrative concern with privacy into a new context. Sona Kathautiya's old cartage arrears are separate from the new freight charge for carrying bamboo planks: recording a claim of receipt is not presented by the text as proof of payment. Sona and Tara's caution about not treating an old transport site named 'Berhi' as an actual confluence of rivers preserves the difference between authentic geography and an archival place-name.

Under the fifth condition, the government's draft assertion that 'all parties agree' is replaced by arrangements for a public copy, an authorised copy containing signatures and objections, and a confidential private annex. Later Ramesh's wife reads and has deleted the sentence, 'Permission for the use of private property is implicit'. A person's presence at a meeting, willingness to observe a public survey and assent to the use of private land are three different states of assertion. The final agreement records five headings with limited responsibilities: patient transport, specified work on the public drain, inspected warehouse materials, kitchen grain and wages, and the public objections register. Its title, 'A Second Working Agreement Within Defined Limits', is realistic about the decision reached rather than a boastful declaration of victory.

Time, Focalisation and the Incomplete Achievement of Disaster Narrative

The entire chapter is woven within one working day at the office: the wet original at dawn, five negotiations and signatures during the day, initial drain work in the evening, and the safeguarding of two copies at night. In that sequence, the 'second agreement' is an event; the successful repair of the drainage is not. Minor work on the drain has begun, but the heavy reinforcing plate has not been installed, the water level is unchanged and inspection of the leak within the hospital remains outstanding. Two vehicles are standing by, but each patient's clinical need must still be

assessed separately. The warehouse consignment under investigation remains sealed; earlier cartage charges and strike-related arrears have not been fully paid.

The narrator's attention is distributed through the speech of Shabnam, Rama, Tulsi, Ruhani, Ramesh's wife, Paro, Sona and Urmila. The limits of many small signatures, in contrast to the senior official's 'single signature', constitute a structure of polyphony in the novel. Yet this does not mean that every voice achieves exactly equal independence. The decisive wording of the meeting repeatedly settles into the documentary language of Rama and Shabnam. Whether such well-formed committee sentences obscure the hesitant, ambiguous or emotionally charged alternative speech of ordinary workers remains an issue for criticism.

In terms of narrative inference, 'a signature was made' is a reason or hetu; the proposition, or sādhya, that 'full consensus was reached' does not follow universally from it, because each signature concerns a bounded page or an exception. Classical terms should not become unthinking analogies: the procedural deliberation belongs to the text, while the critic reads it comparatively through a tradition of narrative evidence. In the final scene, Urmila and Naira joke about next year's Urahi festival and speak of taking leave for themselves. This creates a personal time that insists on rest amid public service. A sip of cold tea belongs to ordinary life outside ethical oratory. The quiet, untriumphant conclusion—that the agreement is not a bridge built over the water but a promise that can be tested tomorrow—corresponds to the sense of the original's final sentence.

The chapter's achievement is to divide the vast crisis of flood and war into many limited, inspectable acts. Yet there is also a risk for the literary reader: five consecutive conditions, so many representatives, and the succession of innumerable receipts and appendices can turn sensuous intensity into something resembling a list. Readers expecting the urgency of battle from the name Shalya Parva will instead encounter a prolonged interval of office caution. Its justification can only be assessed by reading the consequences of disaster in the following chapters of the complete Yuddha Kanda. To proclaim an overall narrative victory on the strength of this one agreement would be premature.

Shalya Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Joint Critical Assessment of Chapters 97–100

Three Ancient Choices and One Modern Multilateral Arrangement

The first three chapters begin with independent scenes from antiquity. In Chapter 97, despite experiencing deception, Shalya takes responsibility for

the burden of his promise. In Chapter 98, Vibhishana leaves his home and kingdom in protest against Sita's involuntary confinement and seeks asylum. In Chapter 99, though he recognises the injustice done to Sita, Kumbhakarna decides to go to war with the defenders of Lanka. This is not the repetition of a single moral formula. All three understand the cost of their own decisions, and the labour of innocents remains an issue on both sides. Chapter 100 has no independent ancient scene; the ethical resonances of those ancient decisions can be read thematically within the five conditions of a modern multilateral document. The description 'intertextuality across two times' is therefore applicable to Chapter 100 at the level of theme, not of dramatised scenes.

Interrelations Among Story Time, Place and Objects

In the sequence of narration, Chapter 97's ancient journey and hospitality camp, Chapter 98's Lanka, sea and Rama's camp, and Chapter 99's passage from sleep to court and departure for war establish acute crises of time. Modern episodes progressively expand across the five conditions of a restricted hospital route, a trial of transport during the strike, Kamlesh's temporary plank, Devi's training and the second meeting in Chapter 100. In the earlier historical setting are the household water pot, a food ledger and debts of kinship; in the present are the wheel, water-measuring staff, wage receipt and office original and copy. Ancient and modern objects are not literally equivalent. Across changed periods, however, the question 'Whose interests have been concealed?' remains operative through those objects.

Three temporal levels deserve attention: the immediate living time of a patient, the workers' arrears and family histories extending into the past, and drainage and inspection extending into the coming season. One successful stretcher transfer, the restricted operation of two vehicles, review of three incorrectly marked training shifts and an agreement under five headings are not 'achievements' measurable by the same yardstick. A genuine test of event density across chapters must count the change of state produced by each event separately, rather than relying on percentages of dialogue or the frequency of words that signify change.

Evidence, Social History and Unequal Rights to Speak

The principal evidentiary distinctions develop across the four chapters: in 97, receipt of hospitality versus military consent; in 98, refuge versus military trust, and consent to an emergency journey versus termination of a strike; in 99, proposed drain repair versus completed work, and a training error versus incompetence; in 100, signatures versus consensus, and inspected goods versus the release of the entire sealed warehouse consignment. The narrative terms pakṣa, hetu, vyāpti and upādhi thereby

become tools of critical reasoning. At some points an unsupported restricting condition in an inference is identified; at others the absence of direct testing is acknowledged. Such an application of classical epistemology does not claim to be equivalent to modern administrative law. It is a tool for understanding the internal discipline of the text's reasoning.

From the perspective of Videha Parallel History, the narrative brings into view, with names and payment entitlements, those hidden inside the 'principal agreement': cooks, a woman driver, a woman sowing seeds in her field, a stonecutter, a leatherworker, warehouse workers, a trainee and landing-place bearers. Yet the question remains open whether their participation in the meeting gives every voice an equal effect on the final language. The stylistic distance between the far-reaching moral clarity of the ancient royal men and the almost legally formulated statements of the modern workers can sometimes make a critic's desired theory more audible than the experience of the people themselves.

Interim Achievements, Objections and Further Investigation

The concrete achievement of this quartet is that power, crisis, compassion and loyalty are none of them treated as unconditional exemptions from responsibility. A patient was brought to safety, but the main drain was not opened; drivers consented, but the strike did not end; Kamlesh's fee demand was challenged, but his rights to the shop were not finally secured; a working agreement was concluded under five headings, but the investigation into Mahesh's murder was not thereby closed. These unresolved outcomes could become a dramatic weakness if later episodes repeatedly returned to the same argument without any new practical change. At present, however, several small real results are established—a stretcher carried across, two vehicles, a review of training attendance, a written objection and limited work on the public drain—so the entire section cannot be dismissed as purely declarative.

As the subsequent chapters are read, it will be necessary to test how many journeys the vehicles made after the restricted period of the second agreement; whether the actual water level in the drain changed; whether the medicines held back were released after separate testing; how the payments of outstanding workers' dues progressed; and whether fresh independent evidence emerged in the investigation into Mahesh's murder. Answers to these questions are not available in Chapters 97–100. It would be particularly improper in research-based criticism to turn inferences into supposed events of the story.

Chapter 101 — The Patient's Time

Time in the Plural: One Hospital, Many Clocks

'The Patient's Time' begins at 5:42 in the morning, when a third drop falls into a brass bowl in the laundry room. The drop does not merely turn the opening into a metaphor for rain; it establishes three concrete facts: Urmila's immediate act of protecting clean sheets, a leak in the interior roof and the obstructed flow of the drain outside. On the first page, Urmila enters 'external flow' and 'internal leakage' under separate headings. This is the chapter's opening epistemic commitment: a single visual effect does not justify a conclusion about a single cause. Even while it is a site of treatment, the hospital compound becomes a physical structure capable of producing risks to patients. This agency of material space is a significant feature of environmental narrative, although it does not, by itself, establish all the causes of the flood or the defects in repair.

In the next textual segment, three clocks show three different times: the wall clock is five minutes slow, the nursing-room clock two minutes fast, and an attempt is made to compare them with a mobile phone. The narrative has opened at 5:42, yet the grounds on which time is authenticated in medical administration are themselves disputed. Aniruddha has the wall clock's error recorded; correcting one clock does not automatically correct the timing of testimony already taken. In this subtle distinction, chronology becomes not merely a technique of the narrator but a material prerequisite for assigning responsibility justly. The problem of the three clocks matters particularly to a reader tempted to conclude too quickly that a patient's loss resulted simply from the late arrival of a vehicle.

The first decisive differentiation among events arises from the conditions of three patients: Saraswati Devi's unstable breathing, Rehana's injured foot and a third patient's clinically determined transfer to another centre. 'A vehicle is available' does not mean 'all patients should be sent away'. Aniruddha's clinical judgement places the patient's physical condition, the readiness of the destination and continuity of ongoing treatment above the mere availability of transport. This decision cannot be criticised simply as 'slow bureaucracy', since the text itself offers grounds for testing the difference between immediate treatment and unnecessary transfer. Nevertheless the story is not an omniscient arbiter of medical ethics: the medical details of Saraswati's condition are limited, and the reader is not given a definitive clinical history.

The Parallel Times of Drivers, School, Laundry and Consent

In segments 5–9, the plot becomes active within a period of waiting. When Madan Raut's school vehicle arrives beside Tulsi's two vehicles, confusion arises that it might be a 'third patient vehicle'. Madan rejects this automatic transfer of meaning. Seven children are waiting at the designated school turn, and folding the benches in the vehicle is no substitute for medical suitability or children's safety. The headmistress's arrangement to send two teachers, complete the school journey and separately record the potential cost of a hospital trip is a real collective decision. This is not merely 'wasted time': in a disaster, the clocks of schoolchildren's lives cannot simply be consumed by the hospital's need for a vehicle. Yet the chapter does not demonstrate a permanent arrangement for every alternative means of transport; the dilemma opens again the next day.

Haricharan Paswan's empty vehicle has a broken latch. He refuses to carry a seriously ill patient but is willing to transport inspected supplies and a family's belongings, subject to conditions. In his ledger petrol, cleaning, the driver's attendance and time spent waiting occupy separate columns. A young driver himself corrects a shift wrongly described as 'empty'. Responding to an offer of half the fare, Haricharan distinguishes his own freedom to reduce his profit from the injustice of cutting the driver's wages. Here polyphony is not simply the number of different speeches: distinct occupational interests and liabilities for risk produce direct conflict in dialogue. The driver's fear, need for rest and actual value of labour are not set up as enemies of a patient's life, but as conditions of a functioning treatment system.

Urmila marks bags of washed and used linen separately with coloured cords. An apprentice's error is prevented, though that error is not wholly disconnected from her exhaustion. Counting seven washed sheets, five clean covers and four bags of used linen, while refusing to add two damp sheets to the clean supplies available, makes the hospital's 'invisible' domestic and professional labour a direct condition of medical safety. This inventory of objects may seem excessively minute, yet the immediate risk —the unauthorised mixing of two categories of material—gives the detail a causal justification. What appears here is not simply 'equivalent women's labour', but technical skill and indispensable knowledge of error prevention.

At Salma Sheikh's temporary service desk, Rehana's identification number does not match. Salma treats medical care and the correction of identity as two different processes. She issues a confidential temporary slip, demands a written reply instead of verbal approval from billing, and understands the employment risk attached to her own temporary appointment. The ethical

decision receives support from the next scene: Rehana's examination is completed at 10:36; treatment can be provided there without transfer, while the original incorrect identity entry has not been deleted. 'Care was given' and 'the official record was permanently corrected' are two different outcomes. Salma receives no dramatic reward for her courage, only limited institutional acknowledgment in the form of a written instruction for the next shift.

Twenty-Two Minutes, Death and an Unresolved Causal Chain

The vehicle enters the gate at 8:59; the temporary gravel slips, Jamir stops the vehicle, and at 9:12 the wheel crosses on a secured plank. The scheduled entry was 8:50; the actual crossing occurred at 9:12. The delay was therefore **twenty-two minutes**. One particular achievement of the narrative is that Urmila immediately corrects a mistaken interval of 'twenty-one': not even a minute in this record of time is arbitrary. But to treat the interval between scheduled and actual entry as the decisive medical cause of death would require a specific connection between the patient's condition, the treatment required, the vehicle's suitability and the clinical decision made. The original text does not decisively establish that necessary causal bridge.

Saraswati Devi is not transferred in her unstable condition; medical staff continue treating her locally. At 9:18 the third patient is transferred; at 10:14 Saraswati's death is certified. The sequence of these three times is the basis of the event register, not a substitute for inference. The vehicle arrived late—established. Saraswati died—established. **She died because of the delay**—not established. The narrator does not erase Shailaja's grief or the question of possible hospital negligence, but does not advance either as a scientific conclusion. Here, leaving an unproved causal relation undecided is not cowardice but ethical restraint.

Shailaja 'began searching for her slippers', though they were already on her feet. This minute scene of grief becomes a moment of bodily dislocation amid the rigid sequence of dated registers. Her words on the telephone —'At the end, her hand was warm'—are a last memory of personhood, not a clinical last statement. The narrator places Shailaja's experienced time opposite institutional time. No definitive psychiatric diagnosis should be inferred from this expression of trauma; what suffices for the reader is that the experience of death exceeds the clock of testimony. Shailaja reports only what she saw, and separately demands an inquiry into the source of the assurances she heard at the hospital.

In segment 24, the destination centre's receiving inventory shows three linen covers against two recorded covers; the third is found beneath the bedding. The four-minute difference between 'arrived' at the gate and 'handed over' in the ward is recorded separately. Such corrections make the

chain of measurement transparent, without allowing the successful transfer to obscure Saraswati's death. At the end, Haricharan's complaint about the blank risk-allowance column, Madan's register showing the arrival of seven children, Salma's written objection, and Urmila's two separate water-safety pages come together. This reconciliation of multiple lines of action forms the chapter's organisational centre.

Narrator, Examination of Evidence and Critical Limits

The density of immediate time stamps is extraordinary: 5:42, 7:27, 8:56, 8:59, 9:12, 9:18, 9:36, 10:07 and 10:14. Yet this intensive minute-by-minute marking is not mechanical proof that 'many events occurred'. The main changes of state are clear: vehicle eligibility was distinguished; arrangements were made for the schoolchildren; Rehana's treatment was prioritised; one patient was transferred; Saraswati died; and channels for a written complaint and instruction were opened. Waiting, dialogue, rest and repeated verification in the background extend narrative duration. This arrangement, which exposes different institutions' responsibilities within the same moment, makes the text realistic. But the extensive minute-level detail leaves relatively little page space for Shailaja's grief—a valid objection concerning artistic proportion.

Focalisation moves between external observation, Urmila's practical vigilance, Madan's concern for children's safety, Salma's insecure employment and Shailaja's experienced loss. The narrator knows a great deal, but presents that knowledge without erasing the characters' incomplete understanding. In narratological terms, the directly measured delay, the medical certification of death, the inferred possible cause and the assurances Shailaja heard rest on four separate bases of knowledge. From the hetu 'a delay occurred', the universal relation supporting the sādhya 'delay caused death' has not been established; the patient's condition, the suitability of treatment and other possible causes form potential restricting conditions, or upādhis. The point is not to impose a formal judicial verdict on a literary scene, but to clarify the language of evidentiary caution adopted by the characters.

The chief locus of the pathos of grief, or karuṇa rasa, lies in Shailaja's memory of the hand and in the scene of the slippers. The current of duty enacted by Aniruddha, Salma and Urmila takes the form of quiet labour rather than a public proclamation of heroic sentiment. The final bowl scene is a structural recurrence: the bowl that was empty at dawn is now more than half full, and fresh drops continue to fall even after its water has been poured away. The incompletion of reform becomes meaningful here not merely as a symbol but against the background of an actual interior leak. The critical question nevertheless remains whether the expansion of administrative pages at the end of a narrative close to death reduces the

duration of the reader's compassion. This chapter's achievement is to reveal 'time' not as one linear clock but as the unequal, mutually affecting entitlements of patients, families, workers, schools, doctors and public services.

Chapter 102 — Layers of Repair

Layers of Soil and Layers of Documents: Direct Evidence at the Opening

'Layers of Repair' opens the morning after Chapter 101, with the spade of Gomati Beldar. When a thin layer of cement beside the drain is scraped away, a seam of yellow earth and a wet structure emerge. The upper slab appeared level, but grit crumbles as soon as a finger touches it. This visible discrepancy—a repair apparently 'complete' on top but unsafe underneath—is the story's real mystery; it would be wrong to read an imagined culprit as already present. Gomati stops two workers lifting baskets and says that although she was made to lay this slab, she was never informed of an inspection of the bricks underneath. The first event is therefore not simply inspection but the interruption of unsafe labour as a result of inspection. Tara ropes off the risk boundary; the hospital's old wing and Saraswati's death the day before lend the scene an emotional memory.

When an officer proposes simply to 'fill the hole', Gomati raises the possibility of 'the mouth of an old watercourse that has been closed'. Her experience matters, but it is not final proof that the channel was fully blocked or that a particular person closed it. Aditi records where, when and by whom bricks containing old lime and new cement were lifted. Entering the objects in a register establishes an accountable chain for the evidence; the existence of an object is not the same thing as proof of a crime. The twenty-two-minute delay from Chapter 101 is mentioned again, but Gomati's soil evidence is not used to establish the cause of Saraswati's death. The plot holds the verification of the past together with protection against present risk, without substituting one for the other.

Different Claims on the Same Ground: Gomati, Amrita and Phulchan

Gomati's old wage register separately records payment for eight loads of earth brought from the Nonthara mound and for filling behind the warehouse. She acknowledges that the earth she carried and the hours she worked fall within her direct knowledge. But responsibility for a map never shown to her, an unknown order or the entire structure of the blocked watercourse cannot be loaded on her shoulders. A contractor's young associate seeks to equate the actual execution of labour with managerial responsibility; Gomati contests this false inference. The novel

thereby presents a worker not as a passive victim but as a knower who defines the limits of evidence.

Amrita Chauhan's seal relating to a collective sale of Nonthara soil is not a document establishing ownership of the land. She expressly acknowledges that limitation while seeking the links between earlier promises of land reform and the revenue records. The contractor's proposal to combine Gomati's wage claim and Amrita's land claim under the phrase 'soil work' is an instance of class-based oversimplification. The two women decide to testify together without substituting one another's entitlements or rights. Tara's two columns, 'land claim' and 'wage claim', make the difference material within their dialogue. The names of caste and community are not merely decorative signs of inclusion; they become necessary to separating the legal subjects of the claims.

The proposal to resettle Phulchan Lodh on eighteen dhurs of land reveals the difference between an equal area on the surface and equal usefulness for living. A sticky layer beneath the dry topsoil, the possibility of growing rice after rain and uncertain irrigation in winter challenge the administration's easy calculation of 'the same number of dhurs'. Phulchan presents two samples and accounts of seed, manure, wages, clearing the channel and transport to market. He is not resisting departure from an unsafe original site; he is resisting acceptance of an untested alternative. This is a story of post-disaster resettlement, but the chapter neither gives final acceptance of the relocation nor effects a transfer of land ownership. The history of land rights, the land's present agricultural use and the wages due remain three separate questions.

The Community Watercourse Day: Celebration and Unexamined Risk

On the annual day for opening the mouth of the watercourse, people gather with drums, flags, fishing nets and markers for safe banks. The story does not dismiss the festival as unnecessary; it gives public visibility to shared memories of livelihoods, local water knowledge and labour. An elder proposes that the embankment be cut that very night, but Gomati refuses, pointing to the hospital vehicle, an iron pipe, unknown infill and deep risks to workers. The elder's inherited knowledge is not false; the altered infrastructure and present hazards are different. This is not a simple opposition between tradition and modern testing, but a question about the fitness of knowledge for its time and place.

Tara sets bamboo poles at three locations and observes the depth and fluctuation of the water level. Even after the rain has stopped, all three points do not recede equally. She writes that the direction of flow has been seen, but its complete causes have yet to be measured. Hira, Ramani and Phulmati's knowledge of fish, nets and river landings contributes to

understanding drainage from the hospital, but does not dissolve their distinct practical interests. A girl asks how precisely the year of an old brick and a new one can be established. Gomati distinguishes seeing a difference between layers from obtaining the exact date by other means. With this questioning child present, local knowledge gains not unlimited authority but a capacity that is open to testing.

The Withdrawal of the Word 'Sufficient': A Real Turn in Responsibility

The decisive event in the middle of the chapter is Aditi's rereading of her first inspection note. Previously it had declared 'minor repair sufficient'. On the basis of new site evidence, Aditi explicitly retracts that claim: 'Claim withdrawn; structural and drainage tests required.' She shows the first date, the restricted scope of the initial inspection and the later revision. Her refusal of a proposal to tear up the first copy is a significant event in institutional memory. The ethical question 'Who made the earlier mistake?' and the practical question 'What is the safe order now?' proceed together. Correcting an earlier error licenses neither carelessness in the face of present risk nor an instant verdict on the culprit's identity.

The contractor's bill shows 'cheap filling, temporary solid slab', a later date of site acceptance and a third date for payment. The time differences among 'work', 'acceptance' and 'payment' are not themselves proof of corruption, although they plainly warrant investigation. The original annex had not been attached during a two-month delay in the file, but Aditi does not treat the deliberate obstruction of the file by any specific person as proved. The similarity in sound between 'Varuna' and 'Varune' does not automatically establish that they identify the same place. Nor are the conflicting memories of two workers folded into one settled narrative. These many incomplete pieces of evidence keep the reader within an investigative process; at the same time, the series of suspicions creates a certain narrative delay.

Half the wages of a woman labourer are entered at the lower rate for 'assisting labour'. Aditi separates what is rightly owed to her from the question of the repair's quality. The scene matters: the fact that the contracted work proves defective does not automatically extinguish fair payment for work actually done. In segment 26, authorisation is restricted to controlled external cleaning, sampling and safe pedestrian inspection; heavy machinery and excavation of the blocked mouth are prohibited. Gomati receives a copy of the order, giving her written grounds on which to say 'no'. This is a real institutional improvement, and calling it 'complete repair of the drain' would contradict the text.

Craft, Temporal Return and the Assessment of Artistic Limits

Saraswati's death recurs in this chapter as an earlier event. Shailaja herself asks for a clear answer about whether the hospital delay should be treated as the cause of her mother's death. The recurrence is not mere recollection: it gives the investigation of medical time in Chapter 101 an uncertain place in the subsequent file concerning structural faults. In the current day of the story, inspection, sampling, separation of claims and revision of an order take place; earlier infilling, promises of land and the two-month administrative delay supply material for analepsis. The narrator's reach is extensive throughout, but does not issue an omniscient declaration about exactly how much responsibility attaches to which cause.

The metaphor of 'layers' is rich in meaning: cement and soil; wages and land; inspection and report; festival and risk; grief and medical evidence. Yet the power of the metaphor should not encourage oversimplification. Possession of soil, a claim to land, a death at the hospital and wages due to workers are not four names for the same legal situation. Judged by the Indian poetics of aucitya, Gomati's act of stopping the spade, the girl's question about bricks and Aditi's revision arise organically from the narrative sequence; the philosophical resonance of incomplete papers remains suggestive. A weakness is that the distributed arguments of Amrita, Phulchan, Gomati, Tara, Hira, Aditi, Shailaja and several officials appear almost too well organised within one chapter, sometimes suppressing differences of social speech beneath a shared administrative vocabulary. Nonetheless, the decisive achievement is that the earlier erroneous conclusion is withdrawn without destroying the original copy, the worker's right to refuse unsafe labour is protected, and the text does not pretend the repair is complete.

Chapter 103 — The Positive Argument

Two Boundaries of Cleaning Work: 'The Surface Path' and 'The Drain Within'

The first scene of Chapter 103 is fashioned from a pointed shard of glass, an old medicine vial and a teenage apprentice's worn slippers, the objects removed with the handle of Rani Halalkhor's broom. A municipal cleaning contractor wants to send two workers into a closed drain of unknown depth, although the previous day's order had withheld permission for heavy tools and entry. Rani declares that lifting glass from the dry outer path and removing silt from within an unknown water opening are different jobs. This is the chapter's first positive argument: not merely saying 'we will not go down', but defining separately the specified area of safe work and the need to test unsafe work. The action has

immediate practical consequences: the apprentice moves away and the risks to workers' bodies become visible.

The contractor's slip headed 'remaining cleaning for the opening of the watercourse' allows the possibility of a linguistic deception or misleading compression. Yesterday's authorised cutting of grass outside is being presented as if today's unauthorised entry within were its continuation. But this heading by itself cannot provide final proof of the contractor's intent to deceive. Rani's five days of outstanding wages are a separate matter; refusing unsafe work is not a legitimate basis for confiscating pay already earned. Keeping these two questions distinct makes the conflict between workers' safety and livelihood real. A formal declaration that 'safety comes first' does not ensure the source of a worker's rice today; the chapter leaves that condition unresolved.

Mamta Hari belongs to a permanent municipal team, whereas Rani works under a contractor. Their wages, employment insecurity and disciplinary risks differ. In Mamta's register the receipt columns for gloves, safe shoes and an environmental test of the enclosed drain are blank. Showing a photograph of gloves in the warehouse is no substitute for actual delivery, the correct size, training or examination of a hazardous atmosphere. Rani insists on hearing each member of her team express their own fear. This limitation of representative speech is important: Rani speaks 'for the team', but does not convert her companions' individual consent into a declaration made in her own name. The social community is not a homogeneous group, but a proximity of individuals with different employment conditions and bodily fears.

Udayana and the Mimamsaka: Debate on Positive Inference and the Burden of the Counterposition

In segment 5, the narrative clearly changes temporal strands, moving from the modern gate to a scholarly courtyard in ancient Mithila. A crack in a wet clay lamp vessel opens a debate between Udayana and his Mimamsaka guest on the positive inference of God. Udayana prevents the initial clay vessel from being treated as decisive proof of the universe itself. On his side, the combination of inert substances, purpose and the ground of knowledge gives rise to an inference of a conscious directing agent. The counterposition, however, questions the extension to the universe of limited observed examples of the relation between an effect and its maker, the agency of an incorporeal creator and the evidence for omniscience. In this disputation the opposing scholar is not a puppet made only to be defeated. The Mimamsaka adduces positive grounds for objections relating to rules, unseen efficacy (adṛṣṭa), action and authorless knowledge.

Udayana restrains his pupil from the habit of making an opposing position weak before answering it. 'The burden of establishing necessity rests on our side' expresses the modest self-discipline of reasoning, not the abandonment of a position. The importance of the scene in the register of events is not that a philosophical conclusion has been proclaimed; it is that the procedure of debate changes. The opponent's position is entered separately on the pupil's palm leaf, and a copy is left for the next sitting. The title 'The Positive Argument' is not a one-dimensional declaration of a proof of God, but a situation of classical dialogue that includes thesis, reason, universal relation, opposed position and the burden of missing evidence.

A woman craftsperson's entrance gives the philosophical example a social grounding. She explains the practical reason for leaving a wet vessel to dry in the shade. Udayana clarifies that the method of drying this particular pot does not prove the ultimate cause of the universe. From the perspective of Videha Parallel History, the dialogue offers an opportunity to recognise the authority of a working woman's local knowledge. A critical limitation remains, however: her identity, livelihood, the cost of firing her kiln and her own tradition of discourse receive little attention. Her intervention risks becoming simply a useful example for the scholar's instruction. The novel respects her craft, but leaves open whether she becomes a full co-decider in the disputation.

A young pupil's question, 'If we see a sweetmeat, why not infer someone who will eat it?', makes philosophical economy visible to the reader. When the subject or pakṣa changes, the supporting reason changes; the existence of an object is not evidence that it has been eaten. This reasoning returns in the modern meeting about cleaning: confirmation of exterior cleaning is not proof that 'the closed drain is safe'; a photograph of safety equipment is not proof that 'workers have received that equipment'; and a municipal order does not prove that 'the contractor's old wage debt has been discharged'. Nevertheless the relation between ancient philosophy and modern labour conflict is a critical analogy, not a chain of historical causation.

The Active Consequences of Refusing Risk, and Unpaid Wages

The modern story resumes in segment 16. Rani elicits the views of six companions separately. One fears losing future contracts, another has breathing difficulties, and the apprentice refuses even to touch the water inside. The result is a refusal to enter a closed drain of unknown depth without testing and a conditional acceptance of safe exterior cleaning. This is not 'work stopped': the conditions of suitable work are being redefined. In an older receipt there are signatures for four days and a claim that equipment was 'supplied', yet the absence of signatures acknowledging

receipt raises a possible financial question. It does not establish that the objects were actually stolen or that a named person is guilty.

Aditi reads out three distinct responsibilities: the temporary pedestrian route, the route for limited patient transport, and structural testing of the main outlet. There can be no entry inside without a safe inspection. Ramani Bind recalls the genuine achievement of cutting the grass outside the previous day and resists the attempt to blame Rani for 'failure of the festival'. Here the local witness does not become a representative of every decision Rani has taken: she gives limited confirmation of a particular action. By noon, rubbish has been removed from the dry exterior strip, the glass-strewn boundary enclosed, and the hospital's patient vehicle directed along another safe strip. These are actual results, but the closed outlet has not been opened.

At the midday meeting, the contractor proposes to write 'work suspended' and defer all questions of wages until later. Rani refuses the uncertainty of 'later'; she makes separate demands concerning the exclusion of hazardous entry, payment for safe hours, wage arrears, equipment costs and an impartial examination. The municipal officer records a written order prohibiting unsafe entry that day and an acknowledgment of the wage claim. Full payment is not made, but the immediate route to forced entry is closed. The positive event is limited to precisely that. Narratologically, 'a written stop-work order' is evidence of a safety decision, not of permanent job security or payment in full. This incompletion preserves the actual difficulty of labour conflict.

Naira prepares two copies: one for the public risks at the site and another for private wages and names. Rani wants to retain her original notebook and to exert conditional control over the public distribution of copies. This is a point about the right to speak, but also a potential future dispute between safeguarding records and the public interest. The brief scene in which Mamta's daughter brings food deserves attention: the difference between the list of objects in the register and what is owed to the household lunchbox, the insistence that the daughter continue her education, and an ordinary moment of sharing pickle with Rani prevent the workers from remaining mere spokespeople for a 'safety policy'. These sensory moments are comparatively few, however; most of the story is given to reasoned dialogue in offices.

The Limits of Applying Philosophy and the Literary Counterargument

In this chapter the ancient scene becomes a relatively independent narrative space across approximately segments 5–15, while the modern sequence flows through segments 1–4 and 16–29. This inserted intertext extends the duration of philosophical inquiry within the obstruction

facing the modern characters. In assessing the philosophical presentation of the Udayana–Mimamsaka dispute, it is necessary to keep the novel's imagined dialogue separate from the actual statements of the classical text. Criticism ought not to assert that this fictional scene historically establishes the metaphysical conclusions of the Nyāyakusumāñjali. The intertextual use of the five divisions (stabakas) of that work is a structural choice in the novel; here the opposing examination of positive inference remains open.

The second sense of 'positive argument' is the workers' active counterproposal: no to hazardous work, yes to safe work; no to arbitrary publication of names, yes to copies governed by rights; no to total waiting, yes to limited service with inspection. This theoretical correspondence is effective, but caution is essential: the Nyāya inference of God's existence and the worker's immediate claim to safety are not the same kind of sādhya. The high abstraction of ancient argument risks diminishing the urgency of the bodily danger in the present. The chapter's important achievement is that both sides of the philosophical dispute remain strong, while the cleaner's dissent finds partial expression in an institutional order. Its literary limitation is that modern characters continually speak in excellent evidentiary language, so risk, delay, anger and disagreement among workers may sometimes be subordinated to didactic coherence.

Chapter 104 — The Question of Power

From an Animal's Hoof to the City's Survey: The Bodily Basis of Power

'The Question of Power' opens with wet mud adhering to the front hoof of a donkey owned by Noorjahan Itfarosh. Finding a crack in its hoof, Noorjahan stops the cart. The clerk orders the bricks to be unloaded, but the slip had specified transport over a dry strip. Here 'power' is not a miraculous invisible capacity: it comprises the exhausted body of an animal, the weight of goods, the surface of the road and the agency of the woman labourer. The bricks have arrived at the gate, but actual delivery, safe animal labour and the place for unloading are not settled. This seemingly minor scene of transport materially anticipates the subsequent question of a bridge.

Sugni Saday brings the attendance list of her team, but the courtyards in her neighbourhood have been left 'blank' on the local drainage map. Before the water can reach the municipal drain, she wants evidence of the water trapped inside the homes. In one house a child's books are on a bamboo platform; in another an old woman cannot walk. Sugni does not compress two different problems into a universal sentence. Separate sheets

are prepared for 'damage to the homes' and 'proposed municipal work'. Insisting that the work hours of each woman and man be recorded instead of paying one lump sum to the entire team, and demanding that the risk survey count as paid work, translate community leadership into economic decisions. She does not seek to usurp anyone else's right to speak: later, an illiterate colleague is permitted to place a thumbprint only after the entire text has been read aloud.

Noorjahan separates three categories: the merchant price of the bricks, her own fee for transport, and the costs of the animal's treatment, fodder and rest. This separation exposes the contractor's convenience in putting the entire cost of risk onto the woman with the assertion 'the animal belongs to you'. But Noorjahan does not claim that every veterinary bill was immediately recovered from the municipality. In the end she pays for treatment herself, receives approval for partial payment of the earlier transport dues, and a hearing date is fixed for the additional journeys. Without attention to the limits of this result, criticism would fabricate a story of 'the complete economic emancipation of animal labour'.

The Gangesha–Mimamsaka Dialogue: Power, Obstruction and Economy

An independent ancient temporal strand begins in segment 7, in Gangesha Upadhyaya's study. Wood that fails to burn because it is wet leads a pupil to the question of the power to produce burning. A Mimamsaka guest offers examples of the capacities of objects, special obstructions, gems and mantras; Gangesha examines the sufficiency of the ensemble of causes, the absence of obstacles and the necessity of assuming an additional invisible entity. This is a dramatic encounter between two theories, not a mockery of either tradition. Answering the question, 'There is fire; why, then, is there no burning?', requires examination of the wood's wetness, the distance of the fire, contact and possible obstructing factors. The mere presence of fire does not amount to a complete causal configuration. Gangesha keeps the word 'defect' distinct from an accusation of moral wrongdoing.

To dismiss the Mimamsaka's theory of śakti as 'unnecessary mysticism' would contradict the text. The visitor argues that the concept of regular capacity explains causal relations, while repeatedly adding 'an unknown impediment' after each failure is itself questionable. Gangesha's side invokes the discipline of economy: insofar as known causes and the absence of obstacles suffice to explain an event, one should examine the grounds for positing another invisible entity. In segment 12, the 'non-apprehension' of a gem not seen indirectly or in darkness is not treated as equivalent to the 'absence' of the object. This testing of narrative validity

resonates with the modern problem of unseen risks inside a closed outlet; nevertheless the later practical decisions in the chapter do not establish the metaphysical victory of either classical theory.

In segments 13–15, the conversation moves to whether the world is an effect and to the inference of an intelligent maker. Gangesha himself raises questions about the reason, the scope of the examples, an incorporeal maker, the number of makers, knowledge, desire and effort, and the limits of a decisive conclusion. This dialogue belongs to the imagined philosophical timeline of the characters; it should not be taken as a verbatim historical transcript of the Tattvacintāmaṇi or any other original treatise. The narrator cautions against anachronism by saying that 'the words of any later book were not spoken in that classroom'. A female pupil's question about wet grain offers a practical test of knowledge. Gangesha says that an argument about the world's maker is not an immediate method for drying today's grain, although the discipline of asking 'Whose statement? What evidence? Where are its limits?' is relevant to both. Philosophy becomes a method of examination rather than a substitute for practical life.

Sugni's Local Measurements: The Political Meaning of a 'Blank' Map

The modern narrative resumes in segment 16. Aditi draws two arrows indicating possible flow: the hospital outfall and water coming down from Sugni's neighbourhood. Sugni objects to making the houses lying between those arrows invisible. Her team collects older silt marks, the duration of flooding, dated pictures and separate evidence from households. The engineer's assistant refuses to regard local measurements immediately as the government's final evidence; Sugni does not demand such finality either. Her claim is limited: the water level experienced by the neighbourhood must not be erased. Local knowledge therefore constitutes a right to assemble evidence, not a rival omniscience challenging state sources.

Tara stops a young man who begins moving a temporary municipal stake because he mistakes it for a boundary of landownership. The false equivalence between a mark indicating risk distance and a property line is immediately corrected. The time of day in photographs, serial numbers on markers and payment for the young man's work as an assistant measurer are three small but actual improvements. An older woman does not want a survey mark on her door because of a previous rumour that houses would be removed. Sugni refuses to measure the interior of the house without permission. This event counters the tendency to suspend private rights automatically in the name of 'public benefit'. A risk map is not land acquisition: the distinction must be preserved through images, consent and words alike.

The hospital's two patient vehicles proceed along a temporarily safe strip. This demonstrates functioning transport, not the achievement of permanent drainage repair. Urmila immediately arranges higher shelving for the medical stores, reducing a concrete risk. She does not assure citizens, without evidence, that the water will have receded by tomorrow. Rani and Mamta maintain the prohibition against entering the unsafe enclosed drain; Sugni allocates safe exterior work after listening to the members' personal time constraints and family responsibilities. At this point, three forms of women's leadership coordinate across distinct professional circumstances, without merging into a single overarching representative.

Noorjahan's Cart: The Threefold Meaning of Object, Animal and Ledger

Noorjahan's cart contains properly fired bricks and half-baked pieces. The average figure 'six cartloads of bricks' does not establish equal quality or equal weight. She wants the actual quantities and place of delivery entered. When the clerk asks, 'If you calculate so much, how will the bridge ever be built?', she points out that there is not yet any authorised order to build a bridge with these bricks. Here is a foreshadowing of the next title: arrival of materials and completion of a bridge are different events. Noorjahan's teenage daughter suggests a dressing for the animal's hoof and a safe journey back with the empty cart. She asks questions about the accounts herself, but Noorjahan encourages her to study rather than taking her into daily work. Animal welfare, women's labour and a girl's time expose costs of the project that are usually overlooked.

At the midday meeting, a municipal representative sees vehicles moving and presses for the drainage work to be shown as 'complete'. Aditi rejects this illegitimate inference from activity to outcome. Tara has three tests recorded separately: the possible line of the old outfall, the current flow, and the load-bearing capacity of the temporary pedestrian strip. The third line carries the subsequent question of the 'bridge' forward. Following an objection to a consolidated receipt, part of Noorjahan's earlier transport arrears is approved; a hearing is scheduled for the additional journeys; attendance for Sugni's safe survey work is entered; and the coordinator's name is added to the neighbourhood risk map. The kinds of 'approval' differ: a portion of money, a date, attendance and a coordinator are none of them final evidence of complete drainage or secure rights.

Narrative Levels, the Concept of Power and the Reader's Critical Burden

The sequence from morning to noon to evening in the modern setting is divided into two parts by the ancient Gangesha–Mimamsaka debate. This intertext across two times continues the Udayana debate of Chapter 103, while acquiring a separate intellectual centre in Gangesha's questions about power and obstruction. In the ancient strand, wet wood reveals the limits of a proposed experiment; in the modern strand the order to unload bricks on a 'dry strip' conflicts materially with actual conditions. The figurative resemblance is effective, but the classical resolution of a dispute about the power to burn is not modern drainage engineering, and the original chapter keeps the two apart.

From the standpoint of Indian poetics, mud on a hoof, bamboo stakes, wet grain and the blank space on a receipt compose a parallel group of meaningful objects. Suggestion, or vyañjanā, makes 'power' not the force of authority but a situated question of ability and impediment. In the framework of Videha Parallel History, the labour and knowledge of a woman carrying bricks, a donkey, cleaning workers, a woman of the Saday neighbourhood, an illiterate worker and a teenage girl gain visibility before the municipality's authorised measurements. Limits must also be stated: each character is extraordinarily conscious of forms; in some places the reasoning is so orderly that the unruly voices of everyday conflict become less audible. A longer dwelling on workers' distinct rhythms of speech, long experience with animals and the local idioms of the village could have deepened the artistic polyphony. In the final exchange, Sugni makes clear that however much water subsided with the wind and slope, the survey itself did not open the drain. This is the chapter's most scrupulous ending: the problem has not been solved, but the ethical and material conditions for examining it have improved.

Shalya Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Joint Critical Assessment of Chapters 101–104

From the Patient's Minutes to the Soil of the Drain: Four Levels in a Causal Network

Across Chapters 101–104 the narrative divides one public crisis into four distinct decisive questions. First: whose time and body are endangered? Second: what structural and archival layers lie beneath a repair that looks complete? Third: what safe alternatives to the work are possible, and what effective institutional consequences follow from workers' dissent? Fourth: what evidence supports propositions about 'power', capability or

obstruction, and how can a local survey avoid being made the municipality's final truth? In this sequence, the safe arrival of a patient, Shailaja's grief, Gomati's testing of a slab, Rani's refusal of risk, Mamta's receipt of equipment, Sugni's measurements and Noorjahan's animal transport are different actions within the same story-world. Eliminating their distinctions would reduce the narrative to the general sentence 'everyone struggles together'.

The central register of event testing shows different outcomes for all four chapters: (1) in Chapter 101, a verified patient transfer, Rehana's treatment in place, Saraswati's death and an unresolved question of causation concerning the delay; (2) in 102, Aditi's withdrawal of the earlier claim of sufficiency, an order for controlled external cleaning, and separate examinations of wages and land; (3) in 103, a written prohibition on entering the unsafe closed drain that day, actual exterior cleaning, with the wage dispute outstanding; and (4) in 104, a better-demarcated risk map, Sugni's recorded attendance, partial approval of Noorjahan's arrears, and load testing yet to be completed. **The closed outlet was not opened; no permanent bridge was built; and the cause of Saraswati's death was not established merely by measuring water.** These three negative outcomes protect the ethical credibility of the narrative's small achievements.

The Movement of Time, Centres of Focalisation and the Right to Knowledge

Narrative time is measured in minutes in Chapter 101; in Chapters 102–104 the daily sequence from dawn to noon and evening becomes predominant. The acute temporal pressure of the first chapter gives way in the next three to the relatively slower pace of testing. In 102, the former contract, promises concerning land, dates on documents and a two-month file delay furnish material for analepsis; in 103 and 104, ancient philosophical strands are clearly interpolated. Although the outline's label 'intertextuality across two times' is attached to 101–102, the original text contains no independent classical scenes there. The independent scenes of Udayana and the Mimamsaka in 103 and Gangesha and the Mimamsaka in 104 are verified. A plan's classification must not be placed above the scenes actually present.

The extension of focalisation produces a distinct body of institutionally grounded knowledge through women: Urmila's medical timing, Shailaja's grief, Salma's documentary courage, Gomati's work as a beldar, Amrita's memory of land, Rani's contractual risks, Mamta's public service, Sugni's neighbourhood measurements and Noorjahan's animal transport. Yet none of these women represents an identical 'woman's voice'. Medical labour, revenue claims, refusal of unsafe work and freight charges follow

different institutional logics. This polyphony succeeds when it gives form to genuinely unequal interests; conversely, the characters repeatedly begin to speak in the same evidentially precise language, raising the issue of the novel's stylistic uniformity.

Narratology, Philosophical Intertext and the Regulation of Evidence

From a narratological perspective, the quartet contains four different relations between direct perception and inference: the observed vehicle delay and the cause of a death; the exposed layers beneath a slab and a culprit's responsibility; a photograph of gloves and actual receipt of safety equipment; and local measures of water levels and the city's permanent land rights. In each case possible upādhis or additional evidence intervene between hetu and sādhya. Criticism should not end with repetition of the word 'evidence'; the moral weight of Shailaja's helpless question and the bodily danger faced by workers fit only imperfectly into legal registers. On the philosophical side, Udayana's positive inference of God and Gangesha's investigation of power and obstruction constitute different centres. Their classical dialogues are imagined reconstructions, not decisive verbatim quotations from the original Nyāyakusumāñjali or Tattvacintāmaṇi.

From the perspective of rasa and aucitya in Indian poetics, Shailaja's slippers, Saraswati's warm hand, drops into the bowl, Gomati's tool chest and the hoof of Noorjahan's donkey transform affect through material objects. These details give the dry forms of accounting human and ecological bodies. Yet the endless forms, copies, signatures, names and subdivisions can fatigue a reader. Narrative caution is the lifeblood of the plot, but the tendency of every character to deliver a complete statement of argument may suppress scene, silence, anger, social prejudice and the asymmetries of disagreement. It is right to acknowledge this possible limitation while recognising the significance of the literary experiment in labour rights and the culture of evidence.

Further Testing: The Unbuilt Bridge and Decisions Before Disaster

The final bamboo marker in Chapter 104 defines only the boundary for safe load testing; it is not a bridge. In reading Chapter 105, 'The Unbuilt Bridge', it is therefore necessary to ask whose measurements were accepted; what load was estimated; how entry onto private and public land was distinguished; and what new decisions were made among the transport interests of workers, patients, animals and schoolchildren. Those matters will retest the achievements or failures of Chapters 101–104. The present conclusion is only this: preventive construction ahead of disaster is not a proclamation that 'repairs are complete', but the written acknowledgment of an incomplete situation, the execution of limited safe work and the provision of space for contrary evidence.

Chapter 105 — Binout's Bridge

Site, Materials, and Restricted Permission: The Chapter's Event Basis

"Binout's Bridge" opens with Tara Binout scraping a knot of bamboo with her fingernail. The difference beneath the yellow and black outer skins, the ground that sank during the night, and yesterday's prohibition marker make the ongoing preparations before disaster visible in a single instant. The narrator begins not with an official notice but with the craftswoman's touch. Narrative authority thus originates in the resistance of matter before it reaches the inspector's document. Yet this does not glorify local knowledge as infallible: Tara herself does not step into the mud, because yesterday's measurement is not guaranteed to remain valid today. The chapter's first resulting state is not a bridge but **carefully maintained indecision**.

The actual sequence in the event register runs as follows. Tara selects bamboo; Lalit demonstrates the difference in the properties of two planks; Shyam Mallik has the separate purposes of woven bamboo used for fishing nets, baskets, and a temporary footway recorded; Hira treats water level and current as different kinds of evidence; and Aditi proposes a sequence of foundation, joints, and restricted load. Meanwhile, Urmila raises the question of patient transfer, and Tara hears four households with four different needs. When an old brick collapses, assumptions about the foundation change; shifting the site makes the timber already cut unusable. A creaking sound during the first load test stops the work; an incorrectly tightened fitting is identified, and independent examination of the metal is ordered. After the second test, restricted use subject to a sixty-kilogram limit is accepted. That is the entire achievement: controlled pedestrian use of a narrow, temporary bamboo footway, not a permanent public bridge, a vehicle route, or a means of transporting patients.

The decisive point in this sequence is that "the work was stopped" is itself a positive event. Remeasuring when the foundation changes, halting a test when a creak is heard, and replacing a faulty fitting before testing again all bring about real changes in the state of the story-world. A mechanical count of indicators of change cannot measure the ethical weight of such events. For example, in textual segment 16, Lalit's intervention against a crowd expecting a headline announcing "Test Successful" carries greater weight than the expectation of an opening. This negative act produces a distinctive climax of **refused inauguration** in place of the conventional climactic celebration.

Bamboo Weaving, Occupational Expertise, and the Narrative Testing of Evidence

In this chapter, bamboo is not merely a natural object but a social material with different functions. Shyam's net obstructs the movement of fish; a basket carries vegetables; a bamboo footway must bear the risks associated with human weight. To assume the same capacity from the same material is an unwarranted generalisation. In narrative terms, a change of subject also changes what must be demonstrated and the qualifying conditions. "It is bamboo" expresses a general property; "it can safely support a specified human load" is a proposition requiring a test. Inferring the strength of a bridge from the success of a fishing net may constitute an insufficient reason. Lalit's timber, Paro's loose bricks, Usha's leather straps, and Harinarayan's iron fastenings are each necessary within their own fields of knowledge, but no property of any single component establishes the safety of the entire structure.

Usha Ram makes a comparative demonstration of the greater grip afforded by her leather sample, but she does not turn it into a universal claim about rainy nights or every kind of footfall. The creak in the first test proves to arise not from the leather but from the slipping fastening. By arranging events this way, the narrative resists the temptation to choose a culprit in advance. The sound as experienced is a direct perception; its cause is not immediately perceptible. Dismantling the component and checking the original bill and dimensions permit a more specific explanation. Even so, replacing the fastening does not demonstrate the bridge's unlimited future capacity. Aditi's test with sacks supplies evidence for a specified season, foundation, and weight. Textual segment 22 explicitly distinguishes a static test of ninety kilograms from an operational limit of sixty kilograms. The numbers have artistic significance: mathematics becomes a language for marking the limits of a conclusion, not an emblem of boundless confidence.

Two distinct evidentiary questions remain. First, the condition of safety under restricted use depends on physical testing, so permission is made conditional on suspension if the water rises. Second, the ownership of the public path, the lease of Ramani's makhana pond, and the neighbour's right to private steps are not established by tests of structural strength. Tara prevents an official from claiming that one public inauguration proves both material capacity and rights over land. The plot clarifies this conflict not through an extended speech of resolution but through separate pages of accounts.

Four Households, an Inaccessible Route, and the Authority to Give Permission

Tara's hearing of four families challenges the error of the "average user," often omitted from the design of modern projects. A child's route to school, an older person's walking stick, a refusal to allow use of a private boundary, and the ownership of a closed house cannot be fitted into one specimen case. Later, the sixty-kilogram condition prevents some people from using the new footway. The story frames this as neither an invitation to "break the rule and enter" nor a permanent exclusion: an alternative safe route is approved. Equality is thereby distinguished from compelling everyone to use the same passage. Yet a legitimate critical question remains: how consistently will the alternative route be inspected over time? The present chapter describes its arrangement and specified use, not a guarantee of its future success.

The community gathering to test boats and tools establishes the narrative's collective time. The customary celebration with drums pauses first for discussion of equipment, work, and safe use. Those in attendance are not automatically turned into construction workers; names are entered only by choice. Parvati's warning strip, Pavitra's knot, Usha's sample, Shyam and Tara's measurements, and Sugni's water survey represent distinct contributions and claims for payment. Here lies a textual possibility for the **Videha parallel-history perspective**: the central story of public construction is rewritten not as an official cutting a ribbon, but as the documentation of craftspeople's knowledge and costs. Usha seeks written permission for the copying of her design. She does not claim an absolute personal monopoly over traditional weaving, but she does demand recognition and limits on the use of her particular local modification. This fine distinction establishes an appropriate distance between sharing knowledge and exploiting an individual craftswoman.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, and Visual Arrangement

From the bamboo skin at dawn through the midday test to written permission in the evening, the chapter proceeds largely in the linear span of a day. Brief references to the past concern the loss of Lalit's old contract, Usha's experience making shoes, and the previous day's prohibition stake. They are not separate historical episodes but causal background for decisions in the present. An earlier narrative outline may suggest the possibility of a "two-period intertext"; this particular chapter, however, contains no autonomous scene from either the Mahabharata or the Ramayana. The thread of crisis linking Udyoga and Bhishma is apparent, but a correspondence between temporal streams cannot be established

solely by naming a parva. That distinction is essential to an assessment of technique.

The third-person narrator shifts among several characters' centres of attention: Tara's fingers, Lalit's memory, Urmila's concern for patients, Usha's design, Sugni's neighbourhood, Hira's boat, and Ramani's lease. This variable focalisation opens spaces for different forms of expertise. Yet conversations frequently end in such orderly formulations of principle that some diversity of actual speech may be diminished. The reiterated terms "separate entry," "limit," and "permission" clarify the narrative's ethics; meanwhile songs, food, sweet potatoes, the taste of cumin, and a slip recording a labourer's lost half-day reconnect this administrative dryness with bodily experience.

Literary Achievement, Counterargument, and Chapter-Specific Conclusion

The chapter's central achievement is the discipline it imposes on public language between "a bridge has been built" and "the bridge is safe." In the closing report Naira records a formulation approved by Tara: a narrow, temporary passage has been opened for limited use, subject to testing conditions. There is progress here without promotional exaggeration. In the last textual segment, Lalit adds the wages lost for half a day; Noorjahan's earlier dues remain outstanding; and the hospital vehicle continues along its old route. The symbolic bridge does not stand gleaming above an incomplete account of actual rights.

There is also a limitation: almost every small labour dispute immediately receives a properly differentiated statement, and discussions of administrative error often resolve into exceedingly explicit moral answers. Consequently, in some places the reader hears a character's ready-made conclusion instead of discovering the struggle's complexity independently. Nonetheless, the failed first test, damaged bridge materials, restricted sixty-kilogram condition, and rule requiring closure as the water rises supply firm resistance to easy didacticism. The actual change achieved by Chapter 105 is not the **victory of a permanent bridge**, but **the establishment of a public right to stop work when an error appears and to permit only demonstrably limited safe use**.

Chapter 106 — Acknowledgment in Treatment

The Iron Chest, Three Registers, and the Recognition of Error

Chapter 106 begins with the opening of an iron chest in a hospital on a rainy morning in 2039. The clinking glass and soaked labels immediately bring the reader close to material objects, but the question is not simply how many supplies the chest contains. When did they arrive, in whose custody were they kept, were they inspected, and who authorised their use? These questions form the investigative route. The contradiction between Urmila's night-duty register and the warehouse responses "the goods have arrived" and "the supplies remain sealed" is the chapter's central conflict. The crisis arises from the conflation of three different actions under the single word "available": issuing goods from storage, physically receiving them, and being able to use them safely in treatment.

The original event register records the following sequence. Aniruddha calls for two original registers and his own signed emergency summary; Salma demonstrates the difference between one verified medicine and a separate chest under inspection; Aniruddha remembers his untested decision the previous night to treat "issued" as "available"; Shailaja keeps the investigation of the medical cause of her deceased mother-in-law Saraswati's death separate from this mistake; Jamuna insists that current treatment not be stopped; and Rama and Shabnam establish a procedure for amendment while preserving the original pages. Later, an employee's unverified claim concerning a telephone call is entered in a separate register. Aniruddha acknowledges the particular mistake; the availability board is corrected into three categories; actual use of the patient vehicle and the hearing of Urmila's past wage claim proceed separately. At the end, one chest has still not arrived.

Aniruddha's admission here is not the sensational collective statement "all the doctors have confessed to a crime." He admits that, without confirming actual receipt at the hospital and acceptance after inspection, he treated materials issued from the warehouse as available and signed the emergency summary. Within these limits there has been a failure of medical responsibility. This does not automatically establish who prepared consignments with inconsistent labels, who murdered Mahesh, or the medical cause of Saraswati's death. The character's confession identifies the scope of responsibility; it does not make him the bearer of limitless guilt.

Evidence and Statement in the Plot: Words, Meanings, and Causes

"Issued," "received," "fit for use," and "available" are not interchangeable synonyms. The story connects an error in the administrative

understanding of words with possible physical consequences. Even if "the goods left the warehouse" is true, the conclusion that they can be used at the hospital has not been proved. Secure transport, handover, inspection, and medical approval are additional requirements. The language itself demands separate delimiting conditions for evidence. Salma's approved bottle and the sealed chest are not conflicting examples; they are two objects subject to different procedures. Aniruddha's summary sheet is therefore not necessarily a wholly false document, but its generalisation is unwarranted.

Rama stops an employee's proposal to tear out the original page and write in a new number. This protects the historical chain in a way analogous to scientific reproducibility: the earlier paper, the time of the mistake, the date of correction, and the reason for it. From an evidentiary standpoint an amendment register is trustworthy only when the route back to the error remains visible. Naira does not recast an employee's oral claim of pressure by telephone as an established "order from an unknown person"; she records that comparison with the call log is pending. Here, reported speech, documentary testimony within the office, and possible improper pressure occupy distinct levels. Investigating the circumstances of the speaker is necessary, but a predetermined accusation cannot substitute for it.

The chapter's three-tier classification of availability is not a mere fondness for tables: it is linked to the timing of treatment. The tiers are (1) physically present and approved, (2) approved but yet to arrive, and (3) undergoing inspection. An absence in the first category may affect a patient's immediate dose; the second calls for transport; the third requires verification of authenticity. Just as "everything is available" can be an unwarranted generalisation, so can "nothing is available." By making these complex distinctions the story establishes an actual practice of correction rather than merely a search for blame.

Women's Voices, Grief, and the Double Timeline of Treatment

Seeing Saraswati Devi's shawl, Shailaja demands a copy of the hospital's error record, but she makes clear that administrative correction is no substitute for her grief. Memory and document complement one another here without taking one another's place. Investigation of the cause of Saraswati's death and the incorrect summary of supply availability are distinct questions. This separation is essential to a judicial-ethical narratology: a family's loss evokes compassion in the reader, but compassion must not become a shortcut to proving causation. A date is fixed for considering Shailaja's question; the cause of death remains undecided.

Jamuna Devi asks from the opposite direction: why should correct treatment be stopped while the incorrect chest is investigated? Anwari decides to continue her daughter Rehana's regular treatment. One family's pursuit of justice and another family's security in present treatment are not contradictory but different temporal needs. Urmila explains that correcting medical records does not settle the earlier arrears and wage dispute recorded in her laundry and service register. The separate account of her labour must not disappear into a celebration of the doctor's public admission; this is a forceful counterposition. Devi Gond's right to ask questions in training grows into the confidence to record a verified limit despite a senior official's instruction. These women are not simply recipients of care: they are producers of knowledge within the system of treatment.

The Ethics of Admission, Institutional Power, and News Construction

Devvrat's representative wants Aniruddha's admission of error to bring the warehouse investigation to an end. Later a municipal official wants to place the burden of all irregularities in supply on the doctor. The proposals seem opposed, but they share a technique: compress a complex causal network into a single document and a single individual. Shabnam asks three limited questions: Did Aniruddha inspect every consignment? Did he approve every payment? How, then, can "the whole responsibility" be his? Merely printing the classical names of fallacies would be insufficient; the story makes this method of questioning work within its action.

In framing a news headline, Naira keeps the specific error separate from the continuing inquiry. The chapter thereby becomes a critique of journalism's construction of truth. Aniruddha permits publication of the public correction but not a patient's private name or the employee's unverified report of a telephone call. Transparency and privacy are not inherent opposites; rights of access differ according to the subject being verified. The certified copy supplied to Shailaja, the statement about the sealed chest under inquiry, and the public medicine list for a changed shift have three distinct audiences and rights of access. Does the novel turn privacy into an excuse to control information? Here, at least, Shailaja receives a copy of the public correction and a date for the medical inquiry, so controlled access to evidence is not total silence.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, Literary Limits, and Conclusion

The chapter moves through a single day, from the chest at dawn to the midday statement and evening vehicle. The recollection in textual segment 5 creates a brief analepsis that explains the origin of the mistake; it is not a scene from another epic time. An earlier outline's possible "two-period intertext" is not verified as an autonomous mythic narrative in this

particular original chapter. The third-person narrator shows Aniruddha's hesitation while preserving distinct speaking positions for Shailaja, Urmila, Salma, Naira, and the employee. The iron chest, blue bag, wet veranda, old and new summary sheets, and leaking roof continually give the narrative subject matter a material background of insecurity.

The significant achievement is the rewriting of the word "acknowledgment": after an error is acknowledged, treatment must continue, the documentary chain must not be destroyed, the cause of a death must not be pronounced automatically, and workers' responsibilities must not dissolve into the doctor's fault. A narrative limitation remains: nearly every character expresses the final rule of evidence in a readily organised sentence; how plausible is such a lucid language of agreement in an actual crisis? Nevertheless, Urmila's outstanding wages, Shailaja's unanswered question, the dripping roof joint, and the one chest still to arrive obstruct a didactic sense of completion. The achievement is not total resolution, but **a specific public acknowledgment of error and the verified continuity of treatment**.

Chapter 107 — Five Signatures

Five Actions on Five Pages: From Written Agreement to Implementation

"Five Signatures" begins when the lock on the warehouse gate refuses to turn. Before allowing the guard to touch it, Rama has the time and condition of the seal recorded. The patient's clock demands urgency, but urgency gives no right to break the chain of evidence. The title raises expectations of a formal conclusion; instead, the five signatures constitute **controlled beginnings of five separate tasks**. Shabnam's five pages concern patient transport, local water measurement and drainage, the handover of approved warehouse supplies, a relief kitchen with equal rights, and arrangements for publicly accessible copies. The narrator ensures that the formal unity of the document does not erase differences in its implementation.

Devvrat makes the first signature for controlled warehouse handover; the consignments under investigation, with mismatched labels, remain under a second seal. Even after the items reach the hospital, Urmila records three separate entries: "received," "usable after inspection," and "for washing." Tulsi signs for a system of safe patient transport, driver rest, and medical staff, not for the withdrawal of drivers' earlier wage claims. Approval for local water measurement allows work on a safe external outlet, while the dangerous inner stretch of the main drain remains prohibited. Ruhani gives the fourth signature after the kitchen's working hours are established and advance wages are actually paid. Rama gives the fifth for distribution of a public summary and protected appendices.

In assessing the event density, the number of signatures matters less than **the actions that follow them**: a vehicle departs, laundry is inspected separately, water flows through the exterior drain, a shelter room opens, khichdi is served, and suitable information is displayed. A photograph of the signatures can be shown on a platform, but it cannot replace evidence of when the work was actually performed. Shabnam repeatedly compares the time of a signature with that of the next immediate action. The title's numerical simplicity thus draws the reader into a multilayered network of implementation.

The Warehouse's Double Seal, Labour Registers, and Distribution of Benefits

Rama does not treat Devvrat's present cooperation as proof of his innocence in earlier affairs. The question of an order related to Mahesh's murder, the origin of the detained consignment, and the incorrect

hospital summary remain under separate investigations. Gopal, a warehouse worker, and the guard have their hours and rates entered. Sona Kathautiya opposes the expectation that she should provide free labour in removing a fence from the government road. She receives an advance for new transport work; her older dues remain outstanding. This bilateral arrangement replaces praise of a powerful owner's generosity with accounts of the actual goods, labour, and cost involved.

The relationship between exemption from blame and cooperation in service is especially important in these events. If Devvrat opens the warehouse today, that does not invalidate an earlier accusation in the classical evidentiary sense or constitute legal discharge: this restricted acceptance of work is a separate fact in its own time. In modern legal terms, it is the discipline of refusing to absorb unrelated cases into a coordinated statement before investigation. From a narratological perspective, to infer the absence of an earlier violent order from the reason for today's controlled handover risks an unsupported extension of inference. Nor does the novel speculate that everyone has committed the same crime or declare everyone innocent.

Food at the Shelter: Equality, Privacy, and Women's Organisational Knowledge

When Ruhani opens the schoolroom, she checks the utensils, wet ceiling, and door latch. The scene begins not in the language of philosophical disputation but with physical accessibility. Admission of four families, an open passage for an older woman, a child's photographic privacy, and disputes over donors' expectations compose a practical grammar of the right to relief. The account explicitly rejects dividing diners by caste and religion, while preserving the option of confidential details voluntarily supplied to meet personal needs. Equality does not mean forcing everyone to sit with the same plate: an older woman eats from a vessel of her own choosing. This small scene shows that equal treatment can be constructed while allowing difference through consent.

The kitchen's "donation" extends only to three days of rice and pulses; fuel, oil, washing utensils, and night work are not automatically included. Through the voices of Ruhani, Rukhsana, Raghu, Chandrika, Kanchan, Mamta, and Rani, the narrative tests the danger of unpaid service labour alongside praise for benevolence. When a woman worker's name is written incorrectly, she corrects it herself; the fourth signature follows only after advance payment has actually been made. This is a living decision by a character, not a general social inventory. The taste of food, disagreement over ginger and cumin, a girl's laughter, and Noorjahan and Sona eating in the same row add small scenes of pleasure to the structure. Amid grief

and disaster, such quiet experience prevents compassion from being required to remain uninterrupted sorrow.

A possible literary weakness exists here as well. The relief meeting identifies correct principles of labour and privacy in an exceptionally orderly fashion, and resistant administrators often concede quickly. Even so, the text does not create a perfect utopia. The shelter roof leaks, calculation of the next kitchen shift is unfinished, and the dishwasher's two hours of work are initially omitted. One day's achievement is not an enduring promise for tomorrow.

Narrative Time, Shifting Viewpoints, and the Critique of Public Writing

The chapter unfolds in a day, from the locked gate at dawn to the last kitchen shift at night. The material sequence of the five pages organises the narration, but locations change continually: warehouse, hospital, river, shelter, kitchen, and public noticeboard. The temporal relation in this multisited arrangement is primarily a series of simultaneous undertakings, not an independent scene belonging to another epic era. Contrary to an initial classification as a "two-period intertext," the original chapter does not contain an autonomous scene of ancient narrative. A literary analogy may be sought in the ethical challenge of administrative repair after injustice; assuming an actual transition between historical periods would be unfounded.

The threefold arrangement of writing by Rama, Shabnam, and Naira deserves particular attention. Rama maintains a public summary of the evidence available; Shabnam determines the bounds of information access and private appendices; Naira's framing of news prevents the glorification of any single individual. The confidential identities on twenty-seven lines do not enter the public list. From a postclassical ethical-narratological perspective, the reader sees reasons for protecting information instead of being offered secrecy merely as a source of suspense. In place of measuring service by a photograph of five signatures, the reader receives plates of food, workers' receipts, restricted boat journeys, the hospital vehicle, and seals upon material under investigation.

Conclusion: Not the Completion of a Contract but the Distribution of Accountability

In the final scene five people return home by different routes. They are not "owners of one pledge"; each has carried out a distinct portion of work. This form of collectivity does not dissolve the coalition into the will of a single hero. The receding water measurement and unfinished embankment, remaining hospital leakage, rice needed by the kitchen

tomorrow, and restricted bamboo footway remain in the reader's view. Hence the proven achievement of "Five Signatures" is the initiation of limited action across five service areas, not a permanent solution to the crisis. The pre-disaster ethical climax of Shalya Parva lies in the idea that a document earns its truth only after actual labour follows it.

Chapter 108 — Beyond the Water Level

The Submergence of the Red Line: Retesting Yesterday's Decision

In Chapter 108, Hira Sahni's red mark on the measuring pole disappears beneath the water in the first light of dawn. The scene immediately re-examines the achievements of Chapters 105 and 107. The water conditions have changed at the site judged safe yesterday. For the new measurement Hira does not uproot the old pole; he plants another bamboo alongside it and records the times of both. Comparison requires the survival of earlier evidence. Madhu stops the use of a boat that has not been tested after repairs. This prohibition does not deny the public need to cross; it demands that permission be reassessed in changed conditions. An official wants to display the document bearing five signatures as evidence of a successful service opening, but Hira asks: on the strength of how many measurements can we declare it safe?

The sequence of events is clear. The red mark goes under water; the whirlpool and three points on the riverbed are inspected; Gopal Majhi compares the straight line on an official map with the river's current behaviour. Of six proposed boats, three are reserved for restricted daytime journeys, one empty boat is held ready for assistance, and the remaining vessels are barred. An alternative plan takes fuel and grain for Rukhsana by a safer upper route. A hospital patient with special needs is to be sent by a land vehicle in accordance with medical advice. News of seepage along the embankment triggers immediate inspection, provisions for workers' safety and wages, and a public warning. Because the water has risen, even the light pedestrian permission for the bamboo footway is temporarily suspended. At night a public map and fresh advice are issued with new timestamps. The chapter's actual climax is **the courage to suspend a newly granted permission**.

The River's Behaviour, Names on a Map, and the Relation of Perception to Testimony

Gopal's objection is not the generic claim that "a local person knows more than an official." He distinguishes evidence concerning the manoeuvre of an empty boat from the behaviour of a loaded one. The blue line on the government map confuses a pre-monsoon transport route with a safe course for boats today. The name "Tirsula" on an old slip does not automatically establish the current measurements of Tilvahak. Gopal also refuses a proposal to write "Gopal Route" in his honour; he asks that the local designation "Old Erosion" be retained and that the geographical evidence be checked again. The central critical point is the threefold distinction among name, place, and time. A map's authority must come

from verification on the ground, not the status of the person named on its legend.

Rama divides the sources into three groups: the words of the old slip, Gopal's direct testimony, and currently uncertain water measurements. This is a practical example of the narrative classification of evidence. The old slip may be a source of verbal testimony, but its present application to the route requires further congruence. Gopal's direct experience is limited to particular vessels and times; the measuring points provide momentary physical evidence of a new state. Inferring the identity of actual watercourses from the resemblance between the names Tirsula and Tilvahak rests on an uncertain general relation. Naira recognises her own journalistic responsibility here: once a false line is publicised, it can become a direct risk to later rescue operations.

Hira's three points—firm sand, moving silt, and a riverbed that has sunk deeper than expected—reveal physical variation within a single water level. Here nature has an active role in ecological narratology. The river is not a backdrop but a dynamic element that changes instructions. Yet to describe it as a purposeful human-like enemy would impose more meaning than the text supports. The river's change is a physical danger; moral fault arises in human decisions made without adequate testing.

Closed Boats, Altered Livelihoods, and a Conditional Route across Private Land

Allowing restricted use of three of six proposed boats, retaining one empty assistance vessel, and stopping unsafe boats is an inconvenient but accountable decision. Fewer boats affect queues of passengers, fuel consignments, and boatmen's earnings. Madhu counts tying up boats, checking ropes, issuing warnings, and maintaining an emergency watch as labour in their own right. An experienced older boatman is not left idle; there is a proposal to employ him, with pay, on shore-based signalling. This redeploys an elder's expertise without treating "experience" as a substitute for evidence about the present current. Experience is not diminished thereby; its function changes.

Sona Kathautiya's alternative grain transport cannot pass over Kiran Raut's private field boundary without permission. Kiran grants temporary access after recording two journeys carrying light grain, the field boundary, and responsibility for damage. The conditions enable the continuity of relief without exploiting the farmer's rights. A slogan about the public interest does not erase individual ownership; limited use and clear rules for compensation are necessary even in a crisis. Yet the small alternative route cannot solve the river's entire transport problem. Rukhsana's fuel supply for tomorrow remains uncertain, and Noorjahan's payment for new

transport is separate from her earlier unpaid dues. The chapter does not conceal these gaps.

The Embankment's Multilateral Risks and the Right to Stop Work

Kishori Darogi brings news of water at the right-hand foot of the embankment. A local adolescent girl's report becomes a valuable early signal in disaster response, but Tara distinguishes seepage, leakage from within, and overtopping before preventing the instant conclusion that "the embankment will break." Devaki Pal's goats are moved, yet she does not surrender the right to inspect the drainage of her own home. Shiva and Sugni's team has the risk allowance, safety equipment, workers' names, and limits within which they may stop work recorded before placing sandbags. This is a particular narrative achievement in labour ethics: emergency labour may be urgently needed, but an emergency must not make workers powerless.

Two women representatives ask whether raising one side of the embankment will drive water into homes on the other side. Public safety does not entitle one neighbourhood to survive by flooding another's courtyards. Aditi does not authorise permanently raising the embankment; measurements, consent, and a separate test of the external outlet are required. In formal terms, the earlier question of "opening the drain" returns within a new causal network, but the altered water level now provides a definite new circumstance. Excessive repetition is a possible criticism, because each meeting again follows the procedure of recording limitations. Nevertheless, the danger has actually increased; it would be equally mistaken to dismiss the scene as empty verbal repetition.

The Reversed Decision about the Footway, Temporal Structure, and Pre-Disaster Suspense

In Chapter 105 the bamboo footway opened subject to a sixty-kilogram limit; here it closes temporarily because the foundation is wet. This is not inconsistency caused by the work's carelessness. It is a deliberately constructed narrative test of the time-dependent definition of "safety." The indispensable physical condition of yesterday's valid limit—a firm foundation—has changed today. The characters suspend present permission without declaring the earlier signature fraudulent. The narrative moves through a concentrated timeline: comparative measurement at dawn, shifting current at midday, a fresh measurement in the evening, and a night watch. No autonomous scene from another epic era corroborates the earlier outline's suggestion of a two-period intertext. The temporal opposition here is principally the experienced difference between "yesterday," "today," and "next dawn."

In her final report, Naira cuts totalising phrases such as "all safe," "everything open," and "everything ready." The notice instead states that three boats are restricted to daytime use; the footway is temporarily closed; a land vehicle is available for patients; both sides of the embankment are being inspected separately; the kitchen continues; and the material under investigation remains segregated. This choice of public language becomes an ethical discipline governing what readers can know. Shailaja's outstanding complaint, Rehana's regular medicines, guards' labour, and leakage inside the hospital keep the story tied to material ground. The reader refuses the declaration of victory that would solve everything in an instant.

Literary Evaluation: Making Uncertainty a Form of Knowledge

The mistaken river name, paired measuring poles, boat hulls, sandy ground, and smoke from the shelter create a sensory atmosphere. Some dialogue is excessively organised in ethical terms: when every expert speaks almost in the language of ideal decision records, differences of individual voice are sometimes diminished. But the rising water tests that world of words. Despite the repeated discipline of written procedures, the physical current demands a new calculation. The tension of events remains.

In the final scene the river's red mark is measured again; nobody declares that "the town has been saved." The five-signature agreement is rewritten within the new risk. The chapter concludes Shalya Parva with an unknown night instead of a victory celebration. From here arises the expectation of the nocturnal agreement of the following Sauptika Parva and the disaster narrative, but criticism must not announce the unseen events of the next chapter as established facts. The final critical conclusion of Shalya Parva is this: **the ethical capacity to suspend an earlier safe decision in the face of changing evidence, in order to reduce the danger of error, becomes central to narrative heroism**.

Shalya Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Comprehensive Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 97–108

Twelve Chapters of Loyalty, Aid, Grief, and Structural Risk

Across the twelve chapters of Shalya Parva (97–108), the narrative travels from an epic crisis of allegiance to the timing of hospital treatment, the subterranean layers of repairs, safe labour, the load limit of a footway, public admission of error, five signatures, and rising water. In the first three chapters, the ancient narrative strands of Shalya, Vibhishana, and Kumbhakarna provide a stage for the double-edged ethics of loyalty; from Chapter 100 onward, the techniques of negotiating modern agreements become increasingly concentrated. In Chapters 103–104, philosophical scenes involving Udayana and a Mimamsaka, and then Gangesha, open questions of causation, power, and obstruction. Chapters 105–108, however, contain no separate autonomous ancient scene: direct conflicts over material conditions, time, and rights predominate. The distribution must not be flattened into the claim that "every chapter contains two historical periods."

Reading the extended chain of causes reveals several levels. Saraswati Devi's death in the hospital is a verified event; the medical cause is not established solely by the vehicle delay. Aditi's initial assessment of repairs is revised by later physical testing; the unsafe interior section of the drain is not immediately opened. The philosophical question of positive inference produces no ideal solution but establishes a discipline of investigation. Tara and Lalit's building experiment yields a restricted footway, whose use is suspended when the water rises. Aniruddha acknowledges a specified error in the summary of availability, but that does not automatically determine criminal responsibility for other warehouse suspicions. Five signatures initiate real assistance, while rising water forces renewed scrutiny. These twelve chapters form a cyclical yet historically advancing structure of **solution → unforeseen risk → new revision**.

Re-reading Yuddha Kanda and the Conflict of Duties

The names of the Ramayana's Yuddha Kanda and the Mahabharata's Shalya Parva organise the narrative paratextually; modern characters are not mechanical reincarnations of ancient figures. Shalya's deceptive speech, Vibhishana's dissent, and Kumbhakarna's participation in an injustice he recognises echo the ethical difficulties of limited agreement in modern relief work, administrative duties, and resistance to wrong. The genuinely new perspective locates heroism less in bloody warfare than in refusing to sign a false load certificate, keeping employees out of an unsafe

drain, correcting an exaggerated hospital summary, and stopping unsafe boats on the river. This transposition still invites criticism: are the many layers of philosophical and epic loyalty being reduced to ethical decisions about corrections to modern records? Readers must work out the complex answer in each scene.

From the standpoint of Indian rasa analysis, compassion is not a solitary emotion. The shawl of Shailaja's deceased mother-in-law, Urmila's exhausted service, Gomati's inspection of repairs, Sugni's account of the ground, Noorjahan's animal transport, and Rukhsana's khichdi construct an extended emotional field of labour, grief, and self-respect. Small moments of humour—the inauguration ribbon, the taste of ginger and cumin, and differences of opinion about khichdi—provide contextually appropriate pauses amid pathos. Their effect will vary with the reader's reception, but their textual presence is unmistakable.

An Integrated Map of the Evidentiary System

The evidentiary foundations of the parva cannot be reduced to the single category of "documents present or absent." At least six distinct classes emerge: records of medical timing and patients' actual conditions; subsurface layers of land and tests of repair safety; bamboo, wood, and fastenings tested as materials and under load; separate counts of goods issued from the warehouse, received at the hospital, and fit for treatment; limited consent by individuals and receipts for wages; and changing river levels, the suitability of boats, and direct local testimony about routes. Each has a different legitimate scope of application. The recurrent word "paper" is therefore not mere infatuation with formality: on close reading the valid purpose of each piece of paper differs.

Through narrative epistemology this chain can be read across historical periods, but the principles of classical Nyaya and modern legal records are not identical objects. Perception, inference, verbal testimony, analogy, and qualifying conditions are instruments of analysis; their use does not automatically turn every modern decision in the novel into a classical cognition of truth. The parva identifies four possibilities of false generalisation: moving from "issued" to "available"; treating a static load test as proof of safety under moving loads; using a water level at one instant to assert a route's safety throughout the day; and inferring the absence of an earlier violent order from cooperation at the warehouse today. This is its philosophical achievement.

Focalisation, the Distribution of Labour, and Videha Parallel History

In Shalya Parva the narrator distributes voices widely instead of allowing one state-centred position to control decisions: Aniruddha, Salma, and

Urmila in the hospital; Hira, Tara, Gopal, and Madhu on the river; Aditi, Gomati, Lalit, Paro, and Harinarayan at the repair sites; and Ruhani, Rukhsana, Raghu, Mamta, Rani, Sugni, Sona, and Noorjahan in relief work. The mere mention of names does not prove polyphony. The characters acquire causal authority when decisions change because of their specific knowledge—for example, the first load test is halted, medicine availability is divided into three classes, fewer boats are permitted, and a condition limiting passage over a private field boundary to two journeys is accepted. The story thereby makes marginalised occupational knowledge an active author of public history.

A limitation deserves equal attention. Many characters employ the same clarity of administrative and rights-based language; the lively social diversity of distinct speech forms is often absorbed into a shared voice of policy instruction. The repeated phrases "separate register," "separate permission," and "inquiry pending" may slow the pace. Yet the story itself demands caution instead of swift decisions made to suit those in power. Criticism should therefore distinguish problems of pacing from the ethical purpose of the subject matter.

Overall Conclusion and the Temporal Threshold of the Next Parva

At the beginning of Shalya Parva, promises of loyalty and help were being questioned. By the end, the need to reread those very promises in light of time and the safety of survivors stands clearly before us. The five signatures in Chapter 107 and the submergence of the red line in Chapter 108 form a distinctive joint structure: immediately after institutional reassurance, a new natural circumstance tests its limits. The story offers not the victory and resolution of war, but a dangerous night. From that uncertainty comes the reader's expectation of the night story of Sauptika Parva; announcing the outcome of the remaining chapters by anticipation would violate critical discipline.

The principal artistic strength of these twelve chapters is the specificity of material detail and decision; the main risks are the recurrence of rule-bound dialogue and occasional didactic explicitness. Nevertheless, the care with which evidentiary limits are established strengthens the novel's ethical centre: **preserving the integrity of earlier decisions while re-examining the conditions of their application, accounting separately for invisible workers' dues, and refusing to impose untested risks on other bodies in the name of rescue**. Shalya Parva reaches completion through these accumulated conflicts.

Sauptika Parva / Yuddha Kanda

Chapter 109 — The Night Agreement

The First Watch of Night: From Five Signatures to Five Actual Tasks

The opening chapter of Sauptika Parva, "The Night Agreement," begins not with the conventional night attack on a battlefield, but with Rukhsana stirring the bottom of a cooking pot and straightening a wet wage register. Two levels coincide in this opening: food as the minimum requirement for survival and the time of the workers who make that food possible. In the novel's first chapter, "The Kitchen of the Dead," life and the record had stood opposed. The kitchen returns here, but the danger is no longer merely an incorrect entry declaring one person dead. It is the disappearance of labourers from the disaster-management records of several institutions. Rukhsana's objection—that the time spent on work already begun must not be struck off—matters because it prevents a tendency to count distribution while treating preparation during a crisis as free. This comparison rests on the novel's long kitchen motif; the narrator does not explicitly reproduce the scene of the first chapter here.

The chapter's event register comprises simultaneous work in several locations. Initially a proposal to enter Kanchan's name for a full eight hours in each of two self-help group registers is rejected. One register contains her actual signature and the other a separate reference to collaboration. Chandrika creates five columns for raw supplies, prepared food, distribution, remaining stock, and labour hours. Kiran Raut asks for a separate weighed receipt for flattened rice left from the sharecropper's portion instead of having it counted as an anonymous donation. Ruhani refuses to put children to sleep in a damp room and proposes an alternative site, without calling it safe before inspection. Salma arranges handovers of Rehana's medicine, monitoring, and family information from watch to watch. Tulsi refuses to send the exhausted Zamir out driving again without rest; Shabnam records the three different evidentiary statuses of three telephone calls. In this multicentred beginning, the agreement is not a great hero's pact but the implementation of separate, small decisions.

The scene at the landing makes the night's disaster suspense concrete. Madhu asks for the distinction between the normal closure of night-time boat services and a possible exception for special rescue. Hira makes exceptional rescue conditional on medical, navigational, and site verification. A young person's report that the water has risen by "two fingers" is not dismissed, but advice is given to record it again with the measurement point and time. Aditi blocks a proposal to descend inside and open the drain; Tara, Shiva, and Sugni undertake external inspection only and have the waiting workers' time recorded as well. What is **not** done—opening an unsafe outlet, operating a boat on a dangerous watch,

or filling the wet room—is an actual narrative decision, because each prohibition alters the distribution of risk.

Verbal Testimony, Direct Perception, and Multiple Uncertainties

From a narratological standpoint Shabnam's telephone register is a particularly important device. To treat "the embankment has broken," "the water behind the bund is high," and a failed connection as the same report of a breached embankment would change the subject, location, and evidentiary status of the words. The existence of a caller and an audible voice is one fact; the reality of the alleged event is another. The young observer's water mark and Tara and Sugni's measurements at different locations are also not direct observations taken at the same point for the entire night. Aditi does not combine them as if they were figures recorded at one instant. The novel does not turn incomplete knowledge into a meaningless silence of "we know nothing." It proposes limited action based on limited knowledge: remeasurement at dawn, classification of reports, and joint examination of fields and homes on both sides.

The document bearing five signatures separately shows medicines actually available in the hospital, restricted warehouse handover, the functioning kitchen, access by vehicle, and incomplete water inspection. Aniruddha does not increase the hospital's "available" figure on the strength of an oral estimate. Instead of demanding access to Devvrat's private sealed store, the team agrees to request checked blankets from the previously approved open stock, while investigation of the private ledger remains pending. Shabnam and Naira continue to distinguish the public summary from the detailed original. The evidentiary chain is more than the gathering of documents: it also defines the scope of immediate authority. A misleading headline such as "Everyone Safe" could induce a household to undertake a dangerous journey. Ruhani therefore asks a young man to report his grandfather's actual condition, not to generalise about the entire settlement.

The decisive medical action is the decision to transport a pregnant woman by a higher land route. The vehicle leaves after separate verification of location, medical need, a trained driver, and family consent. Rama distinguishes three evidentiary states: the vehicle **departed**, **reached the team**, and the patient **ultimately obtained a medical outcome**. By dawn Salma's written report confirms that the woman has reached safe medical supervision; her private name and detailed treatment are not made public. These fine distinctions protect the story from a boastful claim of results. The rasa of disaster lies in uncertainty itself, not in inventing additional deaths.

Night-Time, Movement between Places, and the Narrator's Focal Centres

The chapter spans the first watch of one night through dawn, but the time of narration is not uniform. The scene of vessels in the kitchen and the counting of hours pauses for expansion; the landing, communications room, hospital, and embankment reports come in short sections that appear almost simultaneous. Changes of watch and fresh inspections mark time explicitly. The third-person narrator provides access to outward scenes and to some characters' experiences. Rukhsana's exhaustion, Devvrat's frustration, Anwari's slackened hand, Ruhani's caution, and Rama's waiting cannot be contained in a single consciousness. This is a multicentred organisation, but a high percentage of dialogue alone would not prove polyphony. The real evidence is the characters' different interests and decisions.

The earlier outline's classification as a "two-period intertext" is not confirmed by an autonomous Mahabharata scene in this chapter. The title "Sauptika" opens a semantic door to anxiety at night and the insecurity of sleep, but the story proceeds among modern kitchens, roofs, boats, and vehicles. To declare that the night violence of the Mahabharata has occurred during this modern night would be an interpretative error. The present chapter's central nocturnal ethics involve coordinated wakefulness for rescue, not forbidden violent intrusion. This is the **difference** in the epic relationship. An autonomous ancient scene may occur later in Chapter 113; its contents cannot be imputed here.

A People's History of Labour, Bodies, and Shelter Keys

Kanchan's double register, Chandrika's five columns, and the correction of forty minutes omitted from a dishwashing woman's work reveal the subtle politics of measuring labour in disaster writing. "Voluntary service" may be socially valuable, but showing one body as having worked sixteen hours in two institutions' reports does not double the worker's actual time. In Rukhsana's kitchen, the boundary between help and paid work is explicit; Chandrika's amendment slip acquires as much narrative importance as the distribution of food. This supplies theoretically useful material for the Videha parallel-history approach: a public history includes not only an official night meeting but dishwashing, flattened rice brought from a field, waiting labourers, and boatmen on watch.

Privacy is not only an issue in digital reporting. Anonymous food tokens in the kitchen, a separate eligibility register, Rehana's treatment information, the pregnant woman's private medical condition, and an older woman's house key are forms of independent rights in life. The older woman keeps her own key; Ruhani gives her a dry pouch without taking

away her authority. In this small scene the disaster shelter becomes a place of temporary protection, not "safe imprisonment." The paper boat made by Kanchan's little brother offers a symbolic counterpoint: it may float in a dry dish, but such a child's game provides no evidence of safety in the real river. The line of sunlight at the end offers reassurance, not a solution to the whole crisis.

Literary Assessment and Outstanding Questions

The artistic achievement of the chapter is the structural linking of restricted tasks. Stove, wet register, rope, chalk mark, key, and paper boat are sensory objects that place ethical argument within bodies and matter. There is, however, a limitation in the dialogue. Rama, Shabnam, Tara, Ruhani, Rukhsana, and Hira often immediately formulate an appropriate response in exceptionally orderly rights-based language. Amid crisis the narrator converts confusion, disagreement, and hesitation into reasonable records relatively quickly. There is therefore a danger of administrative instruction slowing the literary movement. Yet to regard this as an unqualified defect would be wrong: the roof still leaks, the source of the embankment report remains uncertain, the private warehouse is closed, and the dawn water measurement is still pending. The final force of the narration lies not in proclaiming victory, but in holding together five real tasks accomplished during the night and five unfinished limitations.

Chapter 110 — The Warehouse Opens

The Key, the Second Room, and the Classification of Donations

The first scene of "The Warehouse Opens" begins with Devvrat's small brass key, darkened with use. Chapter 107 described the controlled handover from the first room; in this chapter the **second** room, containing a mixture of private purchases, donations, and commercial supplies, is opened for authorised inspection. The event must be delimited precisely. Opening the warehouse door neither proves the complete innocence of earlier accounts nor makes everything inside automatically safe for medical use. Rama's condition that attendance times be recorded separates the right to inspect objects from the procedure for protecting evidence. Devvrat strongly asserts his ownership rights. Rama does not abolish the rights of private property; she requires only regulation of place, time, and witnesses in a public investigation.

The preliminary count divides the goods into three groups: immediately usable, usable after cleaning or testing, and under investigation. Urmila opposes sending wet cloth into a hospital treatment room; Tara regards hanging even otherwise sound cloth beneath the leaking roof joint as unsafe. The value of aid depends not only on the donor's intention but on circumstances of use. Of seventeen available rolls, three are mouldy, two have cut knots, and twelve are in good condition, giving the reader a precise quantitative view. But "twelve good" does not mean medically approved for hospital beds: they are allocated for conditional use as dry shelter flooring and screens. At the end, Sona Kathautiya's vehicle takes twelve approved rolls to the shelter. This material outcome establishes the truth of the title; it does not show that the whole warehouse has been "liberated."

The Eighteenth Roll: Absence, Transformation, and an Unproved Crime

A count of seventeen rolls is obtained against an old slip showing eighteen. Sarju the guard checks the issue slip from the first room, but there is no direct receipt record for an eighteenth roll. At this point, to say "one roll was stolen" risks a fallacious inference. The discrepancy in numbers is a perceptible or documentary inconsistency; theft is a separate proposition involving a particular agent and cause. Later, a written workshop note is found on the back of an old weighing slip, explaining that one roll was cut into two smaller tarpaulins. The craftsperson's statement and measurements of the cut sections agree, but the receipt still bears an unclear signature. The result is a change of classification from "theft" to **transformed item—receipt not yet confirmed**. This is an important event

in the narrative because an initial mistaken allegation is corrected without ending the work of verification.

The story maintains the subtle distinction that the negative fact "not found" is not positive proof of "stolen." The possibility of transformation and its confirmation by the workshop weaken the initial accusation, while the receipt signature remains incomplete. This could be read as a literary application of classical discussion concerning presence and absence, but the text does not explicitly cite a formulation from the old treatises. The critical comparison must respect that limit. Devvrat acknowledges a weakness in his accounting system and establishes a rule requiring staff to preserve earlier entries and record amendment dates and reasons separately. An unproved story of theft thus becomes the occasion for actual institutional reform—a principal turning point in the chapter.

The Confidential Ledger: Custody of Evidence and Limits of Private Life

The private ledger contains three thin bound sections: personal loans, transport and cloth purchases, and social assistance. Devvrat's objection is not merely self-serving. Public disclosure of customer details, family medicines, and private debts could harm innocent third parties. Rama accepts a procedure for making limited copies of relevant pages, preserving the unaltered original, and confining the public notice to the statement that "a copy has been secured." Replacing a wet envelope with a dry one, assigning a serial number, recording time, and obtaining receipts from both sides creates a striking visual sequence. The tension in this scene comes not from the excitement of a raid but from reliable custody. When an employee tries to photograph a private page on a mobile phone, Devvrat informs the inspector rather than forcibly taking the device. The demands of investigation and privacy coexist.

An old hospital supply summary and a transport entry in the private ledger show different dates of receipt. Aniruddha's earlier admission forms the background, but the discrepancy does not automatically establish deliberate deprivation of medicines or guilt connected with Mahesh's murder. Rama and Shabnam preserve the proper limits of investigative authority. Evidence also emerges of an authentic gift of medicines on an earlier emergency night. Urmila's distinction—that one verified act of assistance does not erase another inconsistency—prevents Devvrat from being drawn in a single colour as either criminal or saviour. For the first time he begins to doubt the historical reliability of his accounting. This is the beginning of a complex character development, not a declaration of full repentance.

A Closed Drain behind an Open Warehouse Gate

Behind the store Tara and Aditi see the mouth of an old drainage channel and immediately identify physical risks: irregular layers of brick, a concrete deposit, silt, and the possibility of collapse. Shiva performs an external inspection with bamboo; Sugni refuses an instruction to descend into the unsafe interior and demands wages and external sampling. Tara stops public pressure to open the mouth with two spades merely to take a photograph. Although the outer river level has fallen, the source of standing water behind the warehouse has not been determined. This is a two-level arrangement of space: **commercial access opened, ecological outflow closed**. The flow of goods and the flow of water are not the same. At the end, the faint scraping of rope reminds Devvrat that beyond the correct receipt lies a different requirement: a safe route through which goods actually reach human beings.

Rukhsana's public handover register records a claim of ten sacks, seven actually received, two under inspection, and one wet sack. This precise four-column distinction determines the quantity of food available. Chandrika raises the question of additional labour hours: rice may be donated, but their time is not. Sona first secures payment for earlier transport. These are not detached minor episodes. They revise the main story of material donation through workers' ownership of their labour and its actual value. The literary demand of Videha parallel history is corroborated by this second account: a history of relief must include not just donated objects but the dues owed to those who test, carry, and distribute them.

Narrative Technique, Character Contradictions, and Limits of Achievement

The chapter unfolds in the linear time of a day, from opening the lock at dawn to closing the gate at night. The principal expanded scene is Devvrat's warehouse, interrupted by concurrent episodes in the kitchen, shelter, old drain, and river landing. The narrator gives a somewhat closer view of Devvrat's mentality: his desire for public recognition of donations, fear of loss and accounting discrepancies, relief at evidence of a genuine medicine gift, and embarrassment about private records. Yet Urmila, Rama, Sugni, Sarju, and Keshari contest events on the basis of separate claims of authority. Despite the designation "Sauptika Parva," this chapter has no autonomous nocturnal Mahabharata scene. The preliminary suggestion of a "two-period intertext" cannot be taken as a description of its actual scenic construction.

The artistic distinguishing feature is a sequence of material sounds and objects: key, wet envelope, roll, seal, drain, and boat. Through them the

moral complexity of one character, Devvrat, develops gradually. A weakness is possible insofar as many exchanges immediately resolve into fair procedures; the difficult psychological causes of opposing positions receive less space. Yet the real shortfall of goods, uncertain private accounts, medicines under investigation, and closed outlet make the achievement conditional. The final declaration is not “every warehouse has been opened,” but twelve of seventeen safe rolls put into use, the original private ledger preserved for investigation, and the drain still closed. That is the authentic result of the chapter.

Chapter 111 — The Capacity of a Boat

From Warehouse to Landing: The Asymmetry between Authorisation and Physical Load

At the end of Chapter 110, relief goods were leaving the warehouse. At the beginning of Chapter 111, people at the landing assume that this news means boat services are fully available. Hira's first objection confronts the limits of the five signatures with the river's material resistance. Blankets and sacks of grain, a patient's prescription, children, boatmen, and equipment cannot be entered as one undifferentiated line of cargo. Madhu counts passengers, goods, and crew separately. A child may be held in its mother's lap, but its bodily weight is not thereby zero; it requires a place of its own in calculating boat safety. The "five signatures of agreement" and "today's boat load test" are distinct forms of evidence. This essential difference launches the plot.

In their joint inspection Hira, Gopal, Tara, Shyam, and Lalit examine, in turn, the shifting sand at the bank, fresh silt, a crack in the timber, a corroded fastening, and the condition of the wind. The test of sacks placed on a stable section under controlled conditions is not equated with the collective movements of frightened passengers. After the load has been removed, a joint at the back of the first boat leaks. Shyam therefore removes it immediately from the service list. Here the failure of a timber test is not merely an outward spectacle: it produces a struggle over the right to decide between a boat owner's earnings for the day and passengers' lives. Madhu has the inspection watch and the financial loss from withdrawn boats recorded. Safety is not a moral ideal without cost.

Hira records a separate, day-specific limit for each boat: five persons including the boatman in the first, four in the second, and three in the third; cargo weight requires separate testing. The reader must use these figures carefully: they are not permanent rules applicable to all vessels at every time. The first midday journey is completed safely, but the second is stopped when the crosswind changes. To infer the safety of the next trip from the success of one journey is to ignore a changed qualifying condition. Such causally dependent instability makes the river an active determinant of the plot.

Keshari's Boat: Ownership of Timber and a Living Livelihood

Keshari Bin's old boat has a long split and has been barred from use. A buyer offers cash and tries to treat the boat's timber, oars, bamboo, rope, and the public right to travel through the landing as a single purchasable bundle. Keshari distinguishes ownership of private timber from public

rights along the landing route. This is an important action specific to the story: once the object of a right is defined incorrectly, economic compulsion can become an unlimited surrender. Lalit itemises the repair cost into timber, metal, and wages for experienced hands. Keshari hesitates to enter a wage claim for her own work: how will society regard an owner paying herself for labour? The question reveals a class-based obstacle through which self-employment renders labour invisible.

The repair meeting clarifies the advance, outstanding debt, repayment from future income, and ownership after the debt is cleared. Keshari does not sign the sale deed. Nor does agreement on repairs make the vessel immediately fit to sail. The positive outcome has two levels. First, an unauthorised collective seizure under economic pressure is prevented; second, the questions of future use after safety testing and according to river conditions remain open. The decision to record a young apprentice's work and learning hours separately links economic autonomy to the labour education of another generation. If Keshari's emotional refusal to sell the boat simply made a craftsperson's wages another unacknowledged debt, the chapter's ethical achievement would remain incomplete. The story makes that reverse possibility visible.

Qualifying Conditions of Inference: Sacks, Baluaha, and Changing Wind

The chapter offers concrete examples of the relationship between evidence and assertion. The inference that because a static load of sacks was supported, frightened passengers moving from side to side must also be safe is not adequately established. The appearance of the word "Baluaha" on an old timber-transport receipt does not prove the geography of a historic confluence. Yesterday's safe passage does not guarantee that a further trip will be safe in today's wind. In all three cases the subject and what is to be demonstrated have changed: static material weight, the significance of a place-name, and water conditions at a particular time demand different forms of evidence. These distinctions occur in the characters' everyday exchanges. Criticism may compare them with narrative fallacies of inference, but should not claim that complete classical formulas are expounded within the work.

The distributed arrangement of site knowledge is equally notable. Gopal measures three different points of silt; Shyam listens to the timber; Tara tests the combination of loads; Hira assesses handling and sets safety limits; Madhu manages the wage and trip registers. None possesses omnipotent expertise without evidence supplied by the others. This is an achievement in the social distribution of knowledge. In particular, Hira refuses a proposal to use the empty assistance boat for freight at night. The

indispensable reserve capacity of a resource prepared for disaster is itself a form of service.

Deprivation, Waiting, and Journalistic Ethics

A woman carrying a prescription wants to cross at once, but there is no space in the boat. Salma looks for a vehicle by the higher land route. A young reporter wants to capture the woman's distress on camera; she turns her back, and Naira reports the fact of the complaint without showing her private face. Later, the family receives the medicine by the alternative route. The narrative does not reduce the refusal of a boat journey to a meaningless administrative prohibition. It presents the entire sequence of waiting, anger, alternative access, and final receipt. Yet it does not conclude that every waiting passenger found a successful alternative that day. The public notice acknowledges delays. Journalism in the public interest is not decorative background; it is an active stage in the distribution of evidence about events.

Narrative time runs linearly from the gathering at the landing in the morning to the night watch. The recollection of Keshari's old boat and Hira's earlier test creates a brief analepsis, not an independent epic period. The pace develops through repeated tests, stoppages, and further tests. Certain scenes therefore have a procedural sense of recurrence. Yet the leaking plank, crosswind, clause in a sale deed, child's seating position, and alternative vehicle place distinct pressures on similar language. Heroism is not only the successful trip; it is also the ethical skill of stopping the next trip at the right time.

Conclusion: The History of Loads Not Placed on an Unsafe Boat

At the end Keshari herself signs the statement that her boat is unfit for use. Daytime permissions for the three tested boats expire at night, and the assistance boat has been kept empty. The time budget for a boat that does not sail is not zero: it includes the costs of watchkeeping, waiting, ropes, and inspection. The closing statement publicly records why certain loads were **not** placed on the river. The work does not turn disaster protection into a triumphant "voyage of rescue"; it makes responsible public restraint and economic justice central. The artistic limitation is that extensive descriptions of decision procedures leave less time for characters' unplanned emotional worlds. Keshari's attachment to her boat and the woman's anguish over medicine are rare scenes in which complex embodied experience becomes vivid beyond procedure.

Chapter 112 — Ishaan's Hand

The Resistance of Wood: Dismantling the Heroism of Voluntary Labour

"Ishaan's Hand" opens with preparations to move Keshari's old, barred boat to a safely dry location. Ishaan arrives at the landing with a bag of books and offers to help. Shyam's first instruction—where **not** to push—becomes the first test of Ishaan's intellectual self-confidence. Because of the split in the timber, the soft silt, and the danger of uneven force, even Keshari, the owner, cannot give a decisive order without inspection. Ishaan registers for voluntary assistance, but Madhu makes clear that his unpaid work must not reduce another craftsperson's wages, and that his name will appear in the risk register if he is injured. The chapter's central ethical idea is already concrete in this initial action: **participating in work is not the same as taking authority over the work into one's own hands**.

Ishaan attempts to apply force before the first signal; Shyam stops him. During the subsequent coordinated push the skin of his palm is scraped. Devi Gond cleans and dresses the wound and advises Ishaan not to put his hand back into the wet silt. Jhumki's time for education is also checked. This small incident is not a great mythological "punishment" within the chapter's plot: it is a limited experience of labour, injury, treatment, and learning to follow instructions. The traditional prestige of a character's statements does not determine material safety—an argument Hira later confirms again at the landing. The lesson in Ishaan's change is not merely the pain of his hand but his acceptance of another person's skilled judgment.

Two Registers of Credit: Work at the Landing and Revisions to the Book

Alongside the incident at the landing runs the longstanding question of authorship of an earlier book. Harimohan's letter shows that final agreement remains to be reached about three distinct contributions: Ishaan's original philosophical analysis, Maithili's revisions, and Sarita's labour in copying and supplying examples. A young man proposes publicising a photograph of Ishaan's labour on the boat. Ishaan himself acknowledges that this photograph will not erase the mistakes in his earlier book. The school committee wants to advertise his "social commitment," but Maithili refuses to accept that as a substitute for settling the dispute about contributions. This is a highly important critical scene: good work in one place does not automatically pay a debt, whether financial or intellectual, incurred elsewhere. The characters themselves

check the danger of letting public image become a source of judicial authority.

Sarita refuses to equate the commercial rent of her sewing premises with payment for copying the book. She has an advance recorded not as a "gift" but as part payment for labour, and does not surrender her right to testify about the remainder by accepting it. Maithili wants public page references for three certified revisions, not merely acknowledgment that she "raised questions." Harimohan prepares an agenda based on limited evidence, leaving one disputed date uncertain. The meaning of knowledge here is not merely a topic for theoretical reflection. Whose hand changed a sentence? Whose memory produced an example? Whose hours were spent at the copy? These are social questions of source criticism.

The later meeting establishes three outcomes. Maithili's verified revisions will be entered in the public notice with specific passages; the source and date of partial payment for Sarita's established copying work will be recorded, with remaining claims preserved; and Ishaan's assistance at the landing will remain in the landing's labour register, not in the book's authorship document. All three sign separate pages. This "collective agreement" does not declare the characters' roles identical. Original author of the argument, reviser, copyist, source of experience, and voluntary helper retain distinct positions. Such differentiation places the novel's larger question of **name versus work** at the centre of knowledge production.

Categories of Narrative Evidence and Philosophical Self-Discipline

The chapter's philosophical question is not simply whether Ishaan has relinquished his pride. It would be improper to infer complete transformation of character from one conspicuous act of intervention. The subject of an ethical inference is Ishaan's specified work; what must be established is acknowledgment of others' skills. What is the mediating sign? A small injury to his hand is not sufficient evidence. More substantial support comes from his three written decisions: refusing publicity, recognising Maithili's documented revisions, and recording the limits of Sarita's payment. These demonstrate partial self-correction, not complete future innocence. Ishaan's name remains attached to the original argument. Doing justice through revision does not entail the groundless expropriation of everything previously written.

Two distinctions are made practical through the boat. First, Ishaan actually helps push it, but that participation does not confer authoritative competence to determine its carrying capacity. Second, he wrote the original part of the book, but that fact does not establish the absence of Maithili's revisions. As the authorised subject and realm of direct evidence

change, so too does the authority conferred by a name. The story's appeal lies in the comparison: the teacher himself learns to admit "I do not know"; Shyam's final reply makes knowledge a prerequisite to practice. Yet it would overstep the text to identify this as a literal maxim from Bhamati or Tattvacintamani. The larger novel includes these textual backgrounds, but the direct scenes of Chapter 112 principally test social knowledge, experience, and evidence in practice.

Women's Labour, a Girl's Education, and Multiple Viewpoints

Jhumki wants both payment for drying ropes and time for education. If Ishaan's injury were made into a solitary photograph of a "scholar performing manual work," Jhumki's labour as a girl and the boatmen's professional efforts would recede into the background. Madhu keeps Jhumki's name and signature against her work in the landing register. Later, when she gives Jhumki a copy bearing her name for school practice, she covers other workers' private details. Education begins with recognition of one's labour without violating privacy. Usha Ram asks for due credit for her leather fastening design while explaining that it cannot repair the fundamental safety problem in the timber. Before accepting Ishaan's help washing utensils, Rukhsana asks that it not deprive paid workers of their employment. These objections are not simply occasions for instructing the teacher: the characters are determining their rights in their own work.

The temporal arrangement runs from dawn at the landing through the committee meeting in the evening to care for the dressing at night. Memories of the earlier dispute over revisions to the book enter through a letter in the present. This is background history, not an autonomous Mahabharata scene. The third-person narrator can approach Ishaan's discomfort and subsequent admission, while preserving separate viewpoints for Maithili and Sarita. The final scene between Sarita and Naira is especially meaningful: Naira does not turn her mother's response into the headline of her next report. The boundary between public renown and a household's private decision emerges in this small silence.

The Limits of Success and the Artistic Counterposition

The artistic coordination of physical failure, documentary revision, and decentralised heroism is strong. Silt around the boat, the scrape of timber, the red line on the dressing, and Sarita's sewing ledger carry Ishaan's self-correction beyond a sermon into tangible objects. Nevertheless, explicit statements of justice through dialogue become excessive: Shyam, Madhu, Maithili, Sarita, Rukhsana, and Harimohan each offer almost faultless ethical distinctions. Human obstinacy, shame, financial pressure, and the

natural entanglements of unfinished matters are condensed in some scenes. This possible didactic limitation must be acknowledged.

At the close, Sarita has not been paid in full, all Maithili's revisions have not received final approval, Keshari's boat is not fit to sail, and Ishaan's complete transformation of character has not been proved. What has been decided is only the naming of verified contributions, the protection of claims still under investigation, a path for partial dues, and a real register of the voluntary hand at the landing. Through these limited achievements the title "Ishaan's Hand" acquires a double meaning: the injured physical hand and an accountable signature on a document about authorship. Their values are not identical, but the story develops the practice of placing each in its proper relation.

Sauptika Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 109–112

Night, Dawn, River, and the Sequence of Work

The four chapters of the new parva are not merely "four views" of the same event. Chapter 109 centres on multisited rescue during one night; 110 on private ownership under public scrutiny of a second warehouse room; 111 on the conflict among load, capacity, and livelihood on a changing river; and 112 on revising intellectual credit through the experience of voluntary labour. Yet they are linked by the extended process of implementing the five signatures. In 109, kitchen, hospital, vehicle, warehouse, and water-measurement tasks begun earlier receive separate confirmation. In 110, usable rolls from the warehouse's count of seventeen reach the shelter. In 111, an increase in relief goods brings pressure to place unsafe weights aboard boats. In 112, labour on repairs to a barred boat and credit for revisions to a book meet at the same landing. This is the material and moral sequence of causation.

The name "Sauptika" evokes the Mahabharata's violence at night, the vulnerability of sleeping people, and the fear of revenge. Chapters 109–112, however, contain no autonomous ancient Sauptika battlefield scene. This fact calls for correction of any mechanical description of the narrative as a "two-period intertext." Criticism must distinguish the semantic resonance of the title from actual scenic correspondence. In these four chapters the ethics of wakefulness at night lies in labour for safe rescue, not in violence. The full significance of the following ancient narrative can only be determined after its chapters have been read.

Different Delimiting Conditions of Evidence and the Social Uses of Justice

A shared method of reasoning is visible in all four chapters: the authority of a statement depends on its specified subject, location, time, and field of application. An unverified night telephone call is not direct perception of a breached embankment; evidence that a private store was opened is not proof that everything in it is blameless; a static test with sacks does not prove passengers' safety in shifting winds; and Ishaan's help today does not settle the prior book's dispute over authorship. These four errors can be brought under one formulation: **evidence from one field must not be converted into an unauthorised conclusion about another**. The narrative concepts of qualifying condition, pervasion, and fallacy of inference help analyse these events, but the novel does not make every character recite

formulas. Criticism must not misrepresent philosophical analogy as a direct quotation from classical treatises.

Distributed Labour, Women's Decisions, and the Limited Reconstruction of Heroism

Rukhsana, Kanchan, Chandrika, Madhu, Hira, Tara, Urmila, Rama, Shabnam, Ruhani, Sona, Sugni, Sarita, and Maithili are active within distinct fields of decision. The point is not merely the number of women characters; criticism must see their authority over public evidence and the outcomes of decisions. Stopping Kanchan's double-counted hours, correcting Chandrika's omitted labour, Urmila's refusal of unsafe cloth, Hira's suspension of a crossing, and Sarita's demand that her outstanding dues be named correctly are actual exercises of power. To place all these characters into a lifeless category of "people providing service in a crisis" would destroy their differences. Keshari's right not to sell her boat and Ishaan's practice of accepting refusal construct correspondingly less domineering forms of heroism among other characters.

From the Videha parallel-history perspective, these sections gain value as a counterposition to conventional commemorative history. Alongside donors' names, the public record includes the actual use of approved materials, boatmen's suspended watches, a dishwashing woman's forty minutes, an apprentice's cleaning of ropes, and dues owed for a copyist's revisions. A contradiction remains: many characters speak the same polished legal language. Differences of dialect, prolonged emotional uncertainty, and the duration of disagreement among varied caste and occupational positions could have received more space in these four chapters. The urgency of physical risk partly counterbalances the procedural repetition.

The Duration of Narration and the Beauty of Unfinished Results

One night in 109, a day of controlled warehouse inspection in 110, the following day's landing tests in 111, and a day of boat repair and meetings in 112 produce a concentrated, almost day-by-day narrative sequence. Extended dialogue and small movements between locations make dramatic time relatively slow; the watches preceding disaster expand through decision records. The narrative devotes more attention to investigative stages than to a miraculous instant of rescue. The creative strength of this arrangement is that it exposes the complexity of responsibility in crisis; the risks are slow pacing and repeated statements of principle. The deeper characters' inner uncertainty becomes, the more technique becomes literature. If the sequence simply repeats names, slips, and signatures, the story risks becoming an imitation of office procedure.

For now the verified achievements of the four chapters are limited: overnight services continue; some shelter materials arrive safely; some boats complete safe journeys on specified days; Keshari retains ownership and agrees on a procedure for repairs; and arrangements are recorded for verified corrections of intellectual credit and partial payment to Sarita. The main drainage opening, suspect medicines, complete examination of private accounts, permanent approval of boats, and the book's remaining disputes are unresolved. These open conditions form the background to the possible nocturnal shock of later Sauptika chapters. Criticism should not declare as accomplished events that have not yet occurred in the story-world.

Chapter 113 — Ashwatthama's Night

The Beginning of Revenge: A Splinter from the Chariot, Grief for a Father, and the Moral Alternative

In this chapter of Sauptika Parva, the ancient nocturnal assault itself becomes the narrative centre for the first time. Unlike the contemporary disaster management of Chapters 109–112, the opening focuses on a thin splinter pulled from the axle of a broken chariot. Ashwatthama continues to hold it in his palm while Kripa attends to water for a wounded soldier and Kritavarma worries about bandaging a surviving horse. The disparity among these three actions supplies the initial narrative seed: an object held motionless amid anger, the immediate labour of saving a life, and the practical concern of rescuing what remains after war. The splinter need not be treated as a predetermined divine symbol; its meaning emerges from Ashwatthama's injured memory and the seemingly purposeless act of holding on to it.

Beside the lake, the wounded Duryodhana asks briefly, "Son of our teacher, are you still here?" The question brings lineage, loyalty, and loss into a single place. Kripa concerns himself with bandages and treatment before royal honour, while Duryodhana speaks of the dignity of the remaining army and Ashwatthama makes Drona's death into an imperative command to exact revenge. The narrator enters Ashwatthama's memories of his father for a moment: the recollection of Drona examining the boy's fingers before teaching him to string a bow creates a genuine tension between humanity and violence. His grief is real, but the killing proposed on its basis does not thereby become legitimate. This is the chapter's central ethical divergence.

Kritavarma recalls the exhaustion of the camp cooks, charioteers, guards, and horse handlers. He clearly distinguishes belonging to a side in war from consenting to violent wrongdoing. The elderly soldier's rope is connected to the remembered labour of lifting eight wounded men. Ashwatthama briefly perceives the humanity of this work, yet does not abandon his plan. It is not that the contrary argument has gone unheard; the rejection of available alternatives and experience becomes part of his moral decision. The final assessment cannot evade this point by describing the character's violence merely as something imposed by fate.

Owl and Crow: The Fallacy of Deriving Moral Permission from a Natural Scene

The spectacle of an owl falling upon crows from a banyan branch marks the chapter's most consequential epistemic turn. Predatory behaviour in

nature is one directly observed event; the claim that attacking sleeping human enemies is justified is a separate value judgment drawn from it. Ashwatthama makes the former into the reason for the latter. Kripa objects that a bird's hunger and fear cannot provide a licence for human conduct. Narratological analysis can identify a change of subject and an unestablished universal concomitance: the proposition that unwary prey can easily be taken at night does not establish that murdering defenceless human beings at night is consistent with dharma. This is a critical analogy, not a formal recitation of logical formulae by the novel's characters.

Kripa explicitly offers the alternatives of issuing a challenge at dawn, collecting testimony about the father's death, and confronting Yudhishthira with questions. The notable feature is that the plot does not eliminate the possibility of justice in order to make revenge appear unavoidable. An alternative exists; its rejection results from the protagonist's wounded self-respect. The logical limit implied in Kripa's statement that "the grief is yours" matters here: owning one's pain does not confer ownership over another person's life. From the perspective of Indian discussions of aucitya, the relationship lies between subjective compassion and the restraint required when deciding another person's fate.

Kritavarma climbs onto the chariot on the grounds that he cannot abandon Ashwatthama; Kripa asks him about the difference between helping and participating. One person's resolve to commit violence becomes a collective journey undertaken by three men. This narrative progression undermines in advance a possible evasion of responsibility such as "I merely accompanied him as far as the gate." Standing at the gate also creates the conditions that facilitate what follows; the narrator makes that fact explicit.

Time Within the Camp: Rest, Care, and Asymmetrical Violence

The Pandava camp is constituted not through a grand tableau of victory celebrations but through the labour of washing bandages, hanging weapons on pegs, and tending to water for horses and patients. An outer sentry bends to give water to a wounded companion; another guard is injured. These details expose weaknesses in security, but such weaknesses cannot be called consent to violent entry. The enemy's "vulnerability" and an exhausted person's right to rest are competing meanings of the same scene. The narrator's attention shifts among the violent resolve, the wounded soldiers, the attendant, and the assistants. Consequently, this is not merely a psychological study of revenge but a polycentric portrait of unequal experiences within the camp.

Inside the tent Dhrishtadyumna cannot lay his hands on a weapon. Although he says, “If this is a battle, give me a weapon,” he has insufficient time to resist. This killing is not a symmetrical contest in battle but an attack on a defenceless person. There follow the assault upon soldiers in the direction of Uttamaujas and Yudhamanyu, the commotion in Shikhandi’s unit, and the murder of Draupadi’s five sons. The narrator must distinguish those five sons from the five Pandava brothers: telling a story of mistaken targets does not erase the separate lives of the people actually killed. The young men identified in family records only through their fathers’ names receive individual futures and histories of learning through the narration. The parallel-history perspective associated with Videha may find here the re-entry of unnamed servants and lesser-known young lives into the lineage-centred account of the epic.

An attendant places the living wounded before material possessions. Her vessel of water falls; her attempt at rescue remains incomplete, but it would be improper to call that incompleteness a crime. An unsuccessful rescue and a successful killing do not belong to the same order of outcomes. Kripa gestures to one wounded man to move away; Kritavarma briefly clears a passage but subsequently continues to sustain the arrangements for the violent expedition’s entry. Momentary compassion and enduring participation coexist. Because of this contradiction, the moral inconsistency between Kripa’s counsel and his acts is a genuine object of criticism. To proclaim him an entirely blameless embodiment of discernment would not agree with the source text.

Narrative Time, Consequence, and a Re-reading of Sauptika Parva

The chapter’s time span is concentrated between the wounded Duryodhana at evening, the night beneath the banyan, the attack on the camp, and the register of names at dawn. Kripa’s proposal to “wait until morning” and Ashwatthama’s decision to act immediately alter the ethical significance of time. A brief analepsis moves from the external events of the war to childhood recollections of the father; the owl’s attack serves as a figurative anticipation of future violence, not as proof of prophetic vision. The third-person narrator can enter more than one inward state but does not reveal the thoughts of all the characters equally at the same moment. Through the experiences of unidentified attendants and wounded men in the Pandava camp, the narrator’s moral range expands.

At dawn Ashwatthama reports that the Pandava brothers were not found, and Duryodhana asks, “Then who was killed?” That question reverses the story of revenge as “victory”: the intended enemies are alive, while numerous other lives have ended. Kripa insists that the killing of the dead must not be written up as a heroic tale. The arrival at the lake of a woman

looking for her husband, together with a child, asserts a right to information about names, whereabouts, and lives beyond political history. The charioteer's capacity to lift two wounded people, the inquiry into the names of survivors, respectful care for the bodies of the dead, and the dispatch of messages to families establish an actual ethical relation with the life-preserving labour of the earlier disaster chapters. Violence in the ancient night, rescue in the modern night: this is not a simple resemblance but an inverted parallel.

The chief source of artistic success is the obstruction of revenge's claim to heroism. In the depiction of wartime frenzy, extreme cruelty does not become decorative spectacle; the character's private motives, the assistant's fear, the body of the dying soldier, and the labour of ordinary people asking for names reveal cruelty's social reach. The limitation is equally clear: Kripa's ethical arguments are often highly systematic and couched in the modern language of rights, at points narrowing the distance between a character's historically situated ancient voice and that of a modern critic. Ashwatthama's violent inner dissonance is powerful, but the psychological fracture experienced by Kripa and Kritavarma at the gate receives little narrative space. This weakness does not nullify the work; rather, the contradiction between its admonitions and its characters' actions calls for finer artistic elaboration. The chapter establishes only this much: the nocturnal violence has happened; the dead have not returned to life; the story of culpability still remains to be written; and care for wounded lives has begun once more.

Chapter 114 — Medicine and the Breath That Remains

From Water Intrusion to Respiratory Distress: An Immediate Register of Bodily Events

"Medicine and the Breath That Remains" opens not with the clamour of an ancient battlefield but with Urmila lifting a wet sack in the old wing of the hospital. The sack has absorbed water and grown heavy; the muddy stream has advanced two fingerbreadths beyond its former mark. Although the records for the outer drain and the inner leak are separate, the flows converge on the ground. This is the complexity of environmental causation: a shared physical outcome does not establish that its two sources are identical. Urmila does not begin by cleaning; she informs the nursing station so that someone can first decide where to move the patient. The apparently "small" act of ordinary labour—ringing a bell—is the crisis narrative's first decisive change.

The nursing-station clock shows 4:37; the clock at the outer gate is five minutes behind. Jamuna Devi suddenly has difficulty breathing. Anwari restrains her initial instinct to offer water and calls Salma instead. Salma asks for trained help and approved equipment; Aniruddha arrives to check availability and carry out the work of obtaining treatment orders. The material setting of the emergency emerges at the meeting point of an elderly woman's body and a waterlogged corridor. "Medicine" is not merely a benevolent object: without a specified safe source, competent team, and actual availability, the medicinal article is not useful evidence of treatment.

The small treatment room is close but unsafe; the iron panel of the rear threshold is loose, and the tested detour is longer. This time Aniruddha chooses the longer, inspected route over the short, unsafe one. The choice genuinely revises his former inclination but does not guarantee absolute safety. The bed's wheel catches at a wet joint; the iron panel moves and injures his arm. The bed does not overturn, Jamuna does not die immediately, and Aniruddha's arm is injured. These three separate conditions must not be conflated into one sensational "catastrophe."

Aniruddha's Injured Arm: A Redistribution of Medical Authority

Salma's immediate instruction, "Both are patients," provides this chapter's structural formula. Jamuna's breathing crisis and Aniruddha's bleeding wound require different treatment. Although injured, Aniruddha wants to keep directing events; the doctor on the next shift requires him to accept examination and treatment as a patient himself. This is a reversal of authority: the body that habitually made diagnoses becomes an object of

diagnosis. Yet the story makes the exchange of roles not a humiliation of the physician but a lesson in distributing responsibility. Salma and the trained team move Jamuna to a safe room while Aniruddha gives the relevant clinical history without making the final treatment decision.

Aniruddha remembers his earlier error in the supply summary and the inquiry into Saraswati Devi's death. Guilt is present in this analepsis, but the new injury is not a judicial punishment for an earlier lapse; the character himself understands the difference. Shailaja asks for the date of review in the earlier death case and insists that her mother-in-law's questions must not vanish inside Aniruddha's wounded body. Through this scene, the novel maintains a subtle distance between retaliatory karma and institutional accountability. The character's physical suffering does not close the separate investigative file. Such an understanding of moral responsibility warrants comparison with Ashwatthama's wish to "avenge his father" in Chapter 113; no ancient event literally occurs in the modern hospital, however—only the ethical question is repositioned.

Handed Over, Delivered, and Administered to a Patient: Documentary Evidence in Verbs

The medicine box under investigation remains sealed, and supplies are arranged from an approved, safe source. An emergency does not automatically permit the violation of this regulatory boundary. In her training register, Devi Gond has written "medicine delivered," when in fact she has only carried the closed box into the room; the supervisor has her write "handed over." The epistemological force of the narrative lies in this small correction of a verb. Transporting a supply, transferring custody, and actually administering medicine to a patient are three different actions supported by three different kinds of evidence. Confusing them could create a fictitious record of availability in the future treatment history. From the viewpoint of narrative delimitations and verbal understanding, the differences in the action denoted by a word become ethically consequential.

Urmila keeps separate counts of the sheets and bandages used in two rooms: recording one patient's use against another name could lead both to wage deductions and to a false treatment record. Tulsi distinguishes a vehicle made ready for safe transport from a merely "empty vehicle"; separate payment is approved for the driver's waiting time, not for the appearance of having transported a patient. Devi's training, Urmila's linen register, Rukhsana's meals, and Chandrika's hot water constitute the distribution of labour inside and outside the medical institution. The physician-protagonist is not the sole saviour. Remove Salma's decision,

Urmila's clearing of the route, Anwari's warning, and the trained driver's rest, and the narrative outcome itself would change.

Family, Privacy, and the Undecided Future of a "Remaining Breath"

Anwari is not a member of Jamuna's family, but because she has witnessed the emergency she demands that the appropriate contact be informed. Salma does not post confidential medical details on the public list. The daughter-in-law's arrival, her holding of Jamuna's hand, her permission for a limited visit, and the successive communication of news to other family members establish decisions of care by women characters as matters of personal right. There are indications that breathing is improving, but no declaration of complete recovery or discharge from the hospital. Jamuna's response to the touch of her daughter-in-law's palm is true as family experience, not a substitute for medical measurement.

While Jamuna breathes, the drain in the old wing continues to drip. At the end, a sign indicating the new detour is installed. Aniruddha writes "injured; responsibility for direct treatment transferred," and Salma fixes the next inspection time. Their separate pens become a concentrated material image of the division of responsibilities within the narrative arrangement. The fear of Sauptika Parva here is not the violence of interrupted sleep but the labour of sleepless care. Hospital time continues to move; the absence of any single person should not bring the medical system to a halt.

Critical Assessment: Immediacy and Procedural Elaboration

The chapter's temporal organisation extends from the final watch of the night through dawn and midday to the following night shift. At the crisis point, the bed's catching, the panel's collision, and the arrival of instructions receive fully elaborated scenes, while hospital accounting, food, and watchkeeping continue in parallel. The third-person narrator moves among the actions and perceptions of Salma, Aniruddha, Jamuna, Anwari, Urmila, Devi, Shailaja, and the daughter-in-law. Drainage, corridor, and clinical room combine to form a chronotope that actually produces the story; the river is not mere background. Contrary to the promise implied by the term "dual-temporal intertext," this chapter contains no independent ancient scene. Its intertextual connection is therefore established only as an ethical inversion between the name Sauptika and the emergency of treatment.

The most effective artistic achievements are Aniruddha's change of role, Salma's swift decision, and Shailaja's persistent questions. The disaster setting becomes a vehicle for the feeling of karuna-rasa, but not through excessive miracles. A limitation appears after the crisis has been successfully

managed: numerous characters in succession utter exemplary administrative statements. The irregular beat of uncertainty during actual treatment, the family's vacillation, and the differences among individual voices might have been allowed to linger longer. Nevertheless, because the roof and drain, the investigation into the medical death, and Jamuna's future remain unresolved, the novel avoids the artificial happy ending of a triumph without consequences. The "breath that remains" is a time-bound medical outcome, not a declaration that death has been defeated permanently.

Chapter 115 — Permission for the Image

From an Illegible Warning to Visual Evidence: The Limits of Public Knowledge

The chapter opens with a wet red rope and a warning notice that is difficult to read at the entrance to the old wing. Two elderly women stop on reaching the closed route. The sign makes them halt but does not itself certify that the new detour is entirely safe. With the guard's assistance, they pass along the raised veranda. The existence of written information and its intelligibility to the public belong to two different levels. For a person unable to read half-soaked letters, an arrow, a guard, and spoken directions are equally important sources of information. The first alteration in the event register is not a digital publication but guidance to safety amid visual impediments.

Urmila checks that a sheet used during an evacuation has not been declared "missing" and has the words "inspection at dawn" added to the directional sign. This is a truth limited in time: a route that was safe yesterday may become dangerous after today's rise in water. In narratological terms, removing the temporal delimitation of a statement can change what is to be established. Adding a single word—"dawn"—to the sign's copy increases the epistemic accountability of the public warning. Because of this subtle opening, the later episode involving mobile video does not arrive as a sudden homily: it develops the preservation of evidence relative to its time.

The Bamboo Ladder, Gomati's Warning, and the Limit of Thirty to Thirty-five Seconds

An officer hastens the afternoon plan to remove supplies, but Tara and Gomati refuse access without checking the joints and silt. From a distance, Sanket makes a short video containing the rope, wet panel, and moving water in a single frame. At that moment an employee advances with a bamboo ladder. Although Gomati's warning can be heard, an assistant pushes the end of the ladder forward; the panel creaks, plaster falls, and the assistant loses his balance and sinks into the mud. With a rope held by Gopal Majhi and directions from Tara, he comes out safely. The event's outcome is definite: the assistant is no longer trapped; he has suffered scratches; and the sequence in which work orders were issued still requires investigation. The video preserves part of the relative timing, not the full history of how the panel became weak.

The inspector demands the entire phone because he assumes that "everything has been recorded on it." Sanket makes clear that a thirty-to-

thirty-five-second view can be supplied; he does not know what happened in the room before the filming began. Here the witness himself defines the limits of his knowledge. Gomati does not treat the fact that her warning was audible as proof of who was responsible for an old repair. The directly visible event, what was heard, the prior history, and the investigator's inference are different categories. The unestablished space outside the frame matters as much as what the mobile frame contains. The story's social lesson is not the omniscience of photographic technology but the recognition of its incompleteness.

The Document of Consent: A Phone Contains a Life, Not an Open Archive for Seizure

Sanket's discomfort is more than ordinary embarrassment. The phone contains private affectionate messages from a fellow student and conversations about future studies. The officer wants the whole gallery, but Tara says that the restricted footage of the specified panel, water, and audible warning is enough. Naira tells Sanket that supplying the material needed for a public investigation is not the same thing as surrendering the right to a private life. On arriving, Sarita first asks whether her son has been injured and then makes clear that she does not consent to the opening of his entire personal phone. The mother's advice is present, but Sanket remains a participant in the decision himself; to regard the episode solely as an example of maternal representation would diminish his autonomy.

Under Rama's supervision, three documents are prepared: a structural inspection report, an eyewitness statement, and permission for use of the video. The permission is limited to today's panel, the water outside, the warning voice, and the sequence of the assistant's emergence. Private photographs, letters, and messages are excluded. There is no requirement to hand over the password. The original video remains on Sanket's phone; an identified copy records the recipient's name, time, and duration; and public circulation requires fresh permission. The beauty of the procedure is that the characters neither obstruct the investigation nor surrender their entire privacy. Limited cooperation is a third possibility. Differences of object, purpose, time, and recipient give consent a concrete structure.

Gomati permits the use of her warning voice for the investigation but insists that it must not be edited into an admission of intentional wrongdoing. The assistant permits the image of his foot to be used but asks that his household's name, his mother's identity, and his cry not be turned into viral material. A distant nurse appears incidentally in the frame. Rama proposes obscuring that unnecessary figure in the public version while preserving the unaltered original. Different people, different voices,

and distinct uses entail separate consents and rights. Ethical narratology becomes active here through the question: how much risk may one impose on whom in order to preserve evidence?

Focalisation and Psychological Meaning: The Rejection of the Camera Hero

Focalisation in this chapter leans chiefly toward Sanket's experience. His trembling fingers, recollection of private messages, fear of disagreeing with a public officer, and final moments at home form its principal inward perspective. Yet the independent decisions of Tara, Gomati, Naira, Sarita, Rama, Urmila, and Rukhsana prevent him from becoming merely a "brave camera hero." Rather than publicising Sanket's name as that of a hero in a headline, Naira refers to the limited evidence released by consent. The question of representing heroism is thus reformulated: someone standing safely outside the barrier operated the camera, while the team that held the rope accomplished the actual rescue.

A town reporter mocks Sanket's romantic messages in the name of viral dissemination. There is a pointed literary opposition in this scene: rummaging through private records of affection in the name of public interest may itself be an abuse of power. Sanket does not erase his private messages out of fear; he defines the boundary of the inquiry. At home he writes a short note himself: the video does not constitute his whole day or his whole life. This inward utterance establishes a distance between digital-age "proof" and the integrity of a person's life. Sarita's container of rice and her insistence that he eat supply an unforced domestic continuation of the earlier narrative of the kitchen; here rice is also the substance of a pause in digital labour.

Social Labour and Literary Limitations

Rukhsana refuses to let additional work in the relief kitchen be treated as anonymous volunteer service: before any photographs she demands the numbers, the cooks' names, and the payment slips. Urmila puts up a curtain to safeguard patients' privacy. An elderly boatman has the published, location-specific notice read aloud to him instead of being left with rumours. These three scenes provide the social counterpoint to photographic truth: evidence is not only something visible but also trustworthy words, accurate labour accounts, and the protection of personal boundaries. As regards analogy, the video does not license projecting the likeness of one incident onto another accident. Tara says that determining the panel's actual structural weakness requires the earlier repair log and a structural inspection.

The chapter moves chronologically from the warning at dawn to the following night; a few seconds of an accident become the occasion for an extended social debate. This is a disproportion between the duration of the telling and the duration of the event. The artistic achievement lies in presenting digital rights not as a lifeless rulebook but through the experience of a frightened adolescent who learns while protecting his messages of affection. A limitation is that the dialogues set out nearly every conceivable subsection of the permission form, sometimes making the story resemble an instruction manual. The reporter becomes a relatively one-sided unethical adversary; a more difficult, legitimate disagreement between investigative need and privacy was possible. Nevertheless, the event-specific chronology, partial field of vision, and actual rescue keep the discussion from remaining merely theoretical. The final evidentiary limit is clear: one person emerged safely; the restricted video was preserved; the whole phone was not made public; and the structural condition of the old wing has not yet been conclusively established.

Chapter 116 — The Old Wing

A Route Closing: Yesterday's Safety Is Not Evidence for Today

In Chapter 116 the hospital's old wing itself becomes the central spatial agent of the events. At the opening, Gomati sees the swollen earth beneath a peg holding a wet rope; rather than tightening the peg, she demands a new cordon around it and testing of the ground considered safe. When Urmila leaves blank spaces in the register for the former possessions of two patients, she distinguishes their right to reclaim objects from permission to enter an unsafe room. Although Tara sees new fragments of plaster, she does not consider the depth of a crack to have been established from its external appearance. These three opening actions establish a triangular relationship among place, time, and lack of knowledge: fresh damage is visible but its full causal extent remains uncertain; within that uncertainty, a decision to prohibit entry is necessary.

The safe emergence of an assistant in Chapter 115 is no proof that today's structure is sound. Naira does not replay yesterday's video unnecessarily and keeps independent information for reconciling times. The clocks in the rear clinic, at the gate, and on the phone run differently; artificially making them agree to the minute in order to create a single sequence of events would be untruthful. Temporally this is a subtle occurrence: narrative truth is not a timeless present but is restrained by dates and uncertain readings from devices. Yesterday's image is not direct evidence of today's crack.

The Falling Flake of Plaster: The Actual Escalation of Risk and the Administrative Decision

At about eight o'clock two thin flakes of plaster fall near the raised platform; a little later the upper joint of a panel appears to have sagged. Aditi orders everyone to remain outside the prohibited boundary. An elderly patient's bed is taken around by the tested, safe detour, and the patient is given accurate, limited information rather than cause for panic. The engineer cannot say when the entire building will collapse, but neither can he certify the load-bearing safety of the specified section. These conclusions are not simply opposites, favourable and adverse: uncertainty about the time of future destruction and the immediate unsuitability of a structure for use concern different propositions. A safety decision does not require a complete prediction of future collapse.

Opposed rumours spread through the crowd: "All the patients were crushed" and "Nothing happened." Naira repeats neither as fact, instead displaying the official account of the particular section closed and the list

of persons still undergoing verification. Aditi orders the closure of the rear threshold, iron panel, route near the medicine room, and wet veranda, but allows treatment to continue conditionally in two tested, safe rooms. “Safety” here is not the simple emblem of shutting down an entire institution. Closing what must be closed and continuing the treatment that can safely continue are two separate responsibilities.

Near midday another irregular sound comes from an old inner room, and fragments fall from an upper corner of the brickwork. A young labourer wants to retrieve materials from inside because he fears losing his livelihood; Gomati stops him. The loss of wages is real, but accepting danger to life in exchange for pay is not permissible. Following the second sound, **even trained personnel are barred from entering the old wing to retrieve materials**. This is a stricter new decision than the earlier partial prohibition. The final administrative position is not closure of the entire hospital but complete suspension of use of the specifically unsafe structural portion. A definitive report on structural causation remains outstanding; the original text does not support the statement “the hospital collapsed.”

Levels of Causation: Wall, Silt, Drain, Warehouse, and Premature Repairs

Sugni measures separately the water at the mouth of the channel, the wall added during warehouse expansion, and the flow through the half-open outlet. Even though the outside water falls slightly, soil moisture near the hospital does not fall in the same proportion; the water level at one site is not direct evidence of the internal seepage at another. The brick fragments laid beside the warehouse may also have come from different periods. Sugni keeps the samples separate, recording their times and places. Lalit Vishwakarma refuses a small contract to demolish part of the wall immediately and replace it with new bricks, because the roof load, wet foundations, and quantity of materials stored nearby have not yet been assessed. The episode gives the novel’s environmental narrative a social dimension: opening a drainage route might divert water from one field into another household.

The original five-signature relief agreement does not combine the warehouse’s usable goods, the half-open drainage outlet, and the old wing’s permanent structural safety into one certificate. Instead of divine grace, this account relies upon disciplined inspection of local labour, waterways, and the weight of things. Within the narrative context, all three would be bad inferences: from “the warehouse room was opened” to “drainage is complete”; from “the detour was safe earlier” to “it is entirely safe today”; and from “we cannot specify the day on which it might fall” to “continued use is justified.” The limits imposed by vyapti and upadhi

must be recognised. This is a critical reinterpretation testing arguments, not a formal debate about narratology set out in sutra form within the story.

Social Records, Decentralised Voices, and the Agency of Women Characters

Gomati separately records hours of work suspended, oral instructions, and the names of the labourers present. Urmila counts sheets, blankets, bandages, and patients' meals according to their different purposes. Tulsi keeps the safe land route, vehicle fuel, and drivers' rest distinct; Hira does not increase a boat's usual capacity just because the water level has risen; Rukhsana prevents a proposal to cook food inside the unsafe wing. None of this can be explained by the generalisation "the women provided service." Gomati's creation of a barrier, Tara's measurements, Aditi's written prohibition, Rama's correction of timings, Naira's public verification, Salma's treatment decision, and Sugni's water samples each have a distinct knowledge base and decision-making domain. This distribution of responsibility provides suitable textual material for rewriting histories of overlooked labour within the Videha parallel-history approach.

Devavrat submits the receipt for a public consignment for checking but recognises a separate entitlement to proof concerning a private account. Phulo has the matter of her household's wet grain and her child's shelter incorporated into the public measurements. An elderly woman wants her son's old materials recovered; Champa has the woman's name and claim to the objects recorded without allowing anyone to violate the entry ban. The story-space no longer consists solely of "the hospital": home, market, warehouse, field, channel, shelter, and workers' wages are all connected to one material crisis. Naira turns the people's unverified, anonymous fears into a system of named information but refuses to declare "everyone safe" without seeing each person's name. In this unresolved list there is a long echo of the novel's earlier treatment of death records.

Narrative Construction, Recurrence, and the Aesthetics of Limited Outcomes

The narration follows the course of a day, from the first measurement at dawn to the rearrangement of night watches. The fall of plaster at eight, the second sound at midday, and the new notice board in the evening mark different points in the escalation of events. The narrator connects an external attention to objects with Gomati's economic worries, the relation between Tara's and Aditi's decisions, Urmila's fatigue, and Phulo's anxieties about home. Wall, rope, crack, silt, brick, and moving water are not merely decorative images; together they create a directly experienced

material environment of causes and effects. No independent mythic scene appears in this chapter. Rather than mechanically identifying a "dual-time" structure, it is appropriate to understand the connection as an ethical inversion of Sauptika and a fear embedded in the space of the present.

Critically considered, the gradual intensification of structural danger works effectively: the actual situation changes from "someone escaped yesterday" to "the panel has sagged today" and finally to "entry is completely forbidden." Light humour shared by Urmila and Naira amid their fatigue gives a human breath to the paper records' incessant urgency. Yet the reiterated presentation of registers, measurements, permissions, and orders in meticulously reasoned dialogue sometimes makes the narrative move at the pace of an information booklet. In particular, several officials and workers speak in strikingly similar, impeccably logical voices. Polyphony is not established merely through diversity of gender, occupation, and names, but through actual differences in language and mental conflict. Nevertheless, a child's soaked grain, a worker's fear for his livelihood, and the difficulty of moving a patient by a detour interrupt this procedural uniformity. The final decision is valid for the present moment: the prohibited section is closed, treatment continues in tested rooms, claims concerning materials and wages are recorded, and a final structural inquiry into causes and the next day's water testing remain pending.

Sauptika Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 113–116

The Opposing Ethical Directions of Violence at Night and Treatment at Night

The movement from Chapters 113 to 116 creates a decisive intertextual inversion. Ashwatthama makes grief for his father into authorisation to take defenceless lives; Salma, Urmila, Gomati, Tara, and Anwari, on seeing danger at the hospital, establish concrete boundaries in order to preserve lives. In Ashwatthama's camp an attendant and a charioteer lift wounded people; in the modern hospital Urmila and Tulsi maintain limited arrangements for linen, time, and transport. This is not simply "the past is bad and the present is good." Kripa's and Kritavarma's partial compassion is a moral failure distinct from their violent participation, while in the modern hospital the earlier mistakes of the wounded Aniruddha and Aditi's incomplete safety decisions are subjected to tests of accountability. The power of the intertext lies not in an equivalence of eras but in contrary practical answers to the same questions.

Four Different Relations of Evidence

In the first chapter, turning the directly observed predation of an owl into a justification for killing human beings is a fallacy. In the second, the unwarranted inference from "medicine handed over" to "medicine administered to the patient" is prevented. In the third, claims that a short video grants access to an entire private world inside a phone or to the building's earlier history are rejected. In the fourth, yesterday's evidence of a safe route cannot establish today's structural safety. In all four instances, evidence is delimited by its subject, time, source, and domain of application. The analytic devices of paksha, sadhya, hetu, and upadhi are useful in explaining these differences, but they constitute a critical method, not invented quotations from the original philosophical treatises.

Event Density and the Reader's Experience

The event curve of Chapter 113 is formed by an agent's decision and irreversible killing: alternatives → violation of a prohibition → multiple deaths → inescapable remorse. The curve of Chapter 114 is dangerous transfer → Aniruddha injured → treatment under Salma's recognised authority → Jamuna's time-bound stabilisation. Chapter 115 moves from a short rescue video → demand for the entire phone → limited written consent → separation of the original and public copies. Chapter 116 proceeds from growing signs of structural damage → partial prohibition → another fall of fragments → complete prohibition of entry to the

specified section. Each story's decisional outcomes can be separately identified and named anew. There is no need to treat a metric such as "markers of change per thousand words" as an actual count of events.

Narrative Voice, Social Chronotope, and the Critical Counter-position

The ancient night discloses grief for a father's collapse into faulty reasoning within concentrated darkness; the modern chapters expand into successive days of renewed measurement, medical shifts, digital consent, and subsequent orders. The unnamed attendant in the camp, the young charioteer, and the future denied to the young men killed challenge history's conventional register of names. In the modern ward, Urmila's linen, Rukhsana's food, and Gomati's suspended wages provide a more explicit account of the same people's history. The possibilities of karuna and bhayanaka rasa and the testing of aucitya have different results across the chapters: describing the murder of an unarmed man opposes the glorification of vira rasa, while Jamuna's surviving breath is not a theatrical display of charity but a temporary result achieved through labour.

The section also has a distinctive artistic limitation. At points ancient characters adopt an excessively systematised modern vocabulary of policy, while the modern characters repeatedly explain evidence, consent, wages, confidentiality, and limits in exceptionally polished language even in an emergency. As a consequence, artistic uncertainty is sometimes obscured by the repetition of an office-like moral code. Yet the irreversibility of stolen lives, the physician's wounded arm, Sanket's fingers trembling with fear, and Gomati's young worker anxious about his livelihood restore the world's persistent crisis to the reader's bodily experience. None of the four chapters offers a simple happy ending: the dead in the camp do not return, Jamuna's treatment continues, the video does not solve everything about the accident, and the old wing's structural investigation remains pending.

Chapter 117 — Naira's Choice

The Object of Choice: Safe, Unsafe, and Not Yet Tested

"Naira's Choice" opens with three papers laid on the hospital information desk: the closed route through the old wing, the place where Tulsi's vehicle is to turn, and Aditi's evening measurements. All three documents certainly describe the same calamity, but they are not interchangeable. Naira makes three categories in her notebook: "closed," "open under conditions," and "retesting pending." The act of classification is the chapter's first decision. The crisis is not reduced to a binary choice between fear and courage. Her insistence on adding limits of time, location, load, and use to the word "safe" makes the writing of information not an administrative ornament but a condition of the movement of living people. The lantern must remain at the information desk: the meaning of this small opening demand is that another person's body must not pay the price of a decision written in darkness. Yet the availability of light does not entail complete knowledge; the chapter repeatedly returns to that distinction.

Gomati's watch register and the language on the notice board introduce another related problem. The paper has been posted, but water carriers and labourers cannot read the prohibition written on it. The decision is therefore made to communicate the same order orally in several local speech varieties. The difference between a document's existence and its effective communication becomes powerful here. Readers are made to understand that the visible signs of law or an order do not have the same meaning for every member of society. Gomati is more than a sentry erecting barriers. She recognises the fatigue of keeping watch, the temptation to retrieve private possessions, and the practical limits of oral communication. From the perspective of Videha's parallel history, the intellectual labour of workers who make an order usable matters more than the mere authority of the person who issued it.

Medical time and the building's time enter this notebook, but do not merge. Salma describes the distinct conditions of three patients—Jamuna's monitoring, the young man's dressing, and a third woman's changing respiration—while Urmila asks whether the space needed to turn a bed has been tested. Aditi distinguishes the ban on the old northern wing and the rear makeshift walkway from the untested field route and a limited strip to the east. Tara and Lalit test a turn with an empty bed; they do not turn a patient's body into a load-testing object. That an empty bed completes a turn does not necessarily prove that every bed carrying a patient can turn safely. Here lies the chapter's discipline of cause and consequence: permission reaches only as far as the evidence.

The untested soil below Sugni's field and possible diversion of water toward Phulo's house, an uncluttered turning space for Tulsi's vehicle, and Hira's reduced limit of boat service join the emergency within the hospital to a wider geography. A shorter route is not intrinsically a safer route; the availability of a boat is not proof of an inspected plan for loading a patient's bed onto it. The perimeter of the crisis extends through building, landing place, field, warehouse, and home. In environmental narratology, water is not merely a frightening symbol but a changing material force whose effects vary between locations. Socially, saving the hospital does not license flooding a neighbour's house. The narrative handles this conflict without resolving it through a facile account of sacrifice.

Written Limits on Decisions and Personal Space

At 8:47 p.m. Aditi records a new inspection: the outer strip is usable subject to conditions and needs continuous reinspection. Naira immediately separates four limited conclusions: the northern wing is prohibited; the western field path is untested; the makeshift walkway and boat are unsuitable for a patient's bed; only the newly inspected section of the eastern strip is usable. Authority to stop movement does not rest with Aditi alone; Salma and the guards also receive the power to call an immediate halt. This decentralises authority without dissolving accountability. Rama requires a colleague to accompany her. Naira supplies a practical reason for wanting to be in the corridor herself: to observe the real interval between the time a room is vacated and the time a vehicle is received. Her choice is not a theatrical declaration of self-sacrifice but acceptance of a specified responsibility of observation.

The disagreement of families is an essential counter-position for criticism. Jamuna's daughter-in-law fears a delay in treatment caused by the long route; another patient's son demands that a closed door only ten steps away be opened. Their fears are not reprehensible. In response, Urmila points out the unsafe overhead section and Salma explains the treatment timings. Eventually the son withdraws his request for the shorter route and has his right to accompany his mother recorded. Consent at this point is not an unconditional surrender of reluctance but a revision of a request on the basis of new information. There is dialogue between family rights and technical inspection. Even so, the work generally allows expert argument to prevail; a more profound account was possible of the subsequent economic and psychological consequences of ordinary family members' legitimate fears.

The successful transfer of the first young man, together with the recorded arrival time, bandage, and medicine sheet, is a successful test. Salma and Aniruddha disagree about equipment compatibility for the second patient; Salma's decision prevails on the basis of the medical responsibility

presently assigned to her. Urmila's long hours of work without rest, Inder's tools left in a closed room, and the elderly patient's sudden dizziness show that new impediments constantly arise within a planned evacuation. Naira's choice is not an unchanging order but a time-dependent procedure subject to revision. Tara observes new moisture above; Aditi writes "no new load." The earlier success does not make the next turn indisputably safe.

Naira's written decision at the five-party shift desk is the chapter's ethical centre. Devavrat wants to add a line about the availability of warehouse supplies; Naira says it belongs in a separate receipt. The availability of material does not establish the safety of a structure. This formal narrative proposition is not spoken as a formula in the dialogue, but the critical observer can distinguish paksha, hetu, and upadhi. One bed at a time; the power to stop immediately; a limited watch—these short conditions turn the vaguely imposed term "responsibility" into something actionable. The rear wheel's arrival in the southern courtyard is a limited success, not a final certificate of safety. The transfer of one patient remains postponed by a medical decision, while the kitchen vehicle's waiting time is recorded as well. The account discloses different values attaching to bodies, labour, and time.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, Intertext, and Critical Value

The chapter travels from the first watch to the final shift at night. A point on the clock—8:47 p.m.—delimits the truth of its story-world. Narrative time is not a single unbroken stream but a series of repeated tests, pauses, and renewed permissions. Naira's inward thoughts, a brief domestic moment with Kabir's dry handkerchief and bread, and Urmila's sense that "if you count the work, it is more; if you count the rest, it is less" give human rhythm to administrative detail. To regard Kabir's and Naira's silence as an omen of disaster would be to impose the reader's later knowledge upon it; in this chapter it is ordinary, weary closeness. The closing passage expressly says that Naira's decision is not "a vow to give her life." In light of the subsequent accident this statement will constitute an important resistance to retrospective interpretation.

The narrative construction suggests an intertext across two historical times, yet this chapter contains no independent ancient scene from the Mahabharata or Ramayana. Broader ethical reverberations may be sought in Bhishma's vow or the envoy's duty in the Ramayana, but these are not separate narrated events. At the level of rereading heroism, Naira is not the sole rescuer either: Tara, Aditi, Salma, Gomati, Tulsi, Sugni, Hira, Rukhsana, and Urmila change decisions through their respective expertise. Consequently, the chapter's collective focalisation, though often centred upon Naira's notebook, does not depend solely upon her private consciousness.

The chapter's literary achievement is to turn the expectation of a "heroic decision" into a "tested decision." The red line, empty bed, wet measuring rod, bread, and timetable are active elements of the plot. Its limitation is that many characters express their decisions in unusually explicit sentences of reasoned argument, making some dialogues resemble explanations of the rationale for a form. Because nearly every position is expressed in balanced fashion, the possible suddenness of an accident does not become entirely perceptible. Even so, the presence of new moisture and shifting marks raises doubts about an illusion of control. At the end, some patients have been successfully evacuated, the next journey continues, conditional permission for the strip remains in force, other routes are prohibited, and each new inspection may change the decision. This is not a declaration of a safe future.

Chapter 118 — Urmila's Tired Hand

The Worker's Body, the Linen Register, and Cumulative Delay

"Urmila's Tired Hand" opens with her stiff left hand, the wheel of a hospital bed, and a wet sheet. Chapter 117 established the written principle of "one bed at each stage"; here the actual weight of one bed falls upon Urmila's fingers as they grow numb. She says plainly that her exhaustion should not be described after an accident as heroism; the work must be shared. The statement establishes the rights of a worker's body against a grief-centred, mythic idealisation. Urmila delegates work to Devi and a trained attendant as needed, but the complex memory and responsibility involved in the linen register cannot be transferred instantaneously. The story thus opens a distinction between the subjective experience of labour and skills that can be transferred within an institution.

The shortage of clean coverings is not a negligible background detail. Rukhsana has a record of two sheets having gone out, but not the time of handover. Urmila explains that one is with Jamuna and one with the young man evacuated first; a third is needed for the woman patient. It would be questionable to open today's tied bundle automatically under yesterday's permission, but neither would it be proper to force the patient to endure cold because the record is incomplete. Salma's clinical requirement and a check of the safe storeroom together establish a legitimate way of finding the third sheet. Three or four minutes spent looking for the key, and the fourth minute, are not "lost" but experienced time. The story does not immediately make delay into an accusation of moral fault; it distinguishes the written account of time from subsequent investigation of causes.

Urmila's minute attention to names, objects, and time creates a broad echo of the memory of Bhāmati's labour, although this chapter contains no independent Bhāmati-era timeline. Knowing "two sheets" were recorded is much easier than knowing which patient received which clean sheet. The novel grants the epistemic status of labour to forms of women's service usually left anonymous. Yet a limitation should be recognised: Urmila keeps an informal memory of all the registers because no other member of the institution understands how they fit together. Her competence deserves praise, but the incomplete institutional decentralisation is itself a risk. The narrative could have criticised this contradiction more rigorously.

The Instability of a Temporary Route: The Actual Turn in Events

In their new inspection, Tara and Aditi find that the upper damp patch appears darker, but cannot determine its dimensions because the illumination has changed between the photograph and the torchlight. Naira signals that a new bed must be stopped. She does not tear up the earlier permission but writes the amended order beside it. History is not cancelled here: a decision suitable at an earlier time may become unsuitable at a later one. In the treatment room, an elderly patient's daughter is allowed to sit near her for a limited period. The intimacy between daughter and mother and the possibility of physical accident are opposing emotional tones of one scene. Karuna rasa is not merely a foretelling of inevitable death; it can also be the small effort to preserve safe companionship.

The chapter's eventful climax occurs in passages 11–15. Salma stops new entries, while a decision is made to take the bed that has already reached the first turn carefully to a stable point. Four people—Urmila, Devi, a trained attendant, and a bed assistant—are then on the outer strip with the patient. First comes the sound of iron scraping, then plaster falls from above, followed by a sharp sound of wet wood and brick and the sinking of a section. Another part connected to the eastern strip has failed. The text does not say that the previously prohibited old northern wing collapsed. Although the stability of the overhead load was uncertain, the exact moment at which a particular fragment would break could not be fully predicted. To infer from "an inspection had already occurred" that "an accident was impossible" would be a fallacy.

Urmila holds the rear wheel of the bed and becomes trapped; Devi supports the patient's head; the assistant preserves his own bodily safety. Naira does not abandon her notebook and dash into the fragile interior. She repeats the order to the outer guard that no one new is to enter. This moral moment revises the conventional heroic tale's expectation of an immediate bodily rush. An impulsive entrance after an accident could create another entrapment. Yet it is essential to state clearly that the bed is trapped and the people have not come out; this is not a scene of "successful rescue." Rukhsana extinguishes the stove instead of trying to save a hot pot; Kanchan and Chandrika take the children to a safe room; Tulsi keeps the vehicle entrance open. These immediate acts of different kinds of protection embody collective knowledge.

Voices in the Dust and the Limits of Reassurance

There are discrepancies among three clocks at the time of collapse; Aditi, Tara, and Rama do not possess a single complete timestamp. Rama writes the sequence—sound, falling material, another sound, prohibition of

entry. From a narratological perspective, the observed occurrence, its sequential relation to other occurrences, and the determination of cause are separate stages. Faced with devices showing different times, to flatten the history of an event onto an arbitrary clock would violate the evidence. Naira establishes voice contact with Urmila across the dust but records "evacuation route; not yet received." Urmila insists that they must not be declared to have arrived before they actually do. Here the register does not stand in for a living person; it is incomplete evidence of that person's real arrival.

Salma asks about the breathing and neck position of the trapped patient; Devi answers only to the extent of what she can observe. Aniruddha, with his injured hand, hands over medicines and the team's responsibilities outside. Naira tells the daughter the confirmed news that a voice has been heard, promising neither a complete rescue nor announcing death. The physical distance of "two rooms" becomes immeasurable in time because of the unstable debris. The attraction of assuming that a short distance means a short rescue time is exposed, alongside the insistence on trained inspection that counters it. Events continue, but the exit remains closed.

A thin rope allows messages and light supplies to be sent from the safe outside position; it is not approved to support the weight of a human being. A bottle of water reaches the trapped group. Urmila drinks two sips; after Devi and the assistant jointly take part of the bed's weight, her trembling hand gains some relief. Instead of casting the tired woman's body into a posture of obligatory "sacrifice," this small change grants her a need to survive, the support of a team, and the right to health. In the final lines Urmila makes clear that a register cannot substitute for living people. This is an important return to the original narrative's opposition to death registers, but it is not a final resolution.

Testing Artistic Achievement and Limitations

Scene-time is densely concentrated. Numb fingers, the corner of a sheet, a bed wheel, the veil of dust, falling plaster, and a breaking sound lend the account a tactile quality beyond the dry language of a register. Through the third-person narrator, the story moves between proximity to Urmila's body and the more distant focal positions of Naira's register, Tara and Aditi's inspection, and the daughter waiting for news. One accident becomes an experience distributed across several locations. There is no independent ancient story-scene in this chapter; a suggestion of dual-time narration should not be mistaken for evidence of an actual narrated event. There is nonetheless an ethical inversion of the Mahabharata's violent night in Sauptika Parva: there human beings knowingly attack, whereas here people attempt rescue amid structural danger.

The artistic risk is double. On one side, repeatedly stating inspection, permission, and pause can turn the reading experience into a procedural report; on the other, immediately after the accident every character speaks in language that is very orderly, sounding more coherent than the shattered awareness of actual fear. Yet the numbness of Urmila's bodily pain and the helplessness of being unable to reassure the daughter keep life's instability alive within that ordered language. The only certain outcomes of this chapter are these: a new part of the building subsided; one patient and the evacuation team were trapped; contact exists by voice; there is no immediately suitable rescue route; neither a total collapse nor any death has been established.

Chapter 119 — The Distance of Delay

Two Rooms: Spatial Distance and Immeasurable Rescue Time

"The Distance of Delay" begins with the line in Naira's register that bears the patient's name but leaves blank the time of arrival outside. The blank is not the negligence of a failed clerk; it is an honest record of a journey still unfinished. The distance of only two rooms between the ends of the corridor—at moments an arm's length, at moments the far bank of a river—is the narrative's central chronotopic image. Debris, unstable beams, and untested loads mean that a fixed physical distance no longer corresponds to a definite quantity of time. The chapter continuously counters the easy assumption that "if the distance is short, the delay is unnecessary." The patient's daughter repeatedly wants to go forward. Naira undertakes to carry her questions inside but does not permit her to cross the forbidden boundary. Two kinds of right—receiving information and entering a dangerous place—are not identical.

Tara and Lalit's measurements indicate that they do not yet know where the overhead load will shift if the beam is lifted. This negative knowledge embodies scientific discipline: admitting that one cannot identify the signs of a possible danger is itself useful information for making decisions. Gomati tells the workers that this is not a test of courage; rescue inside will be possible only if the team outside remains alive. The statement reverses the ordinary expectation of heroic rasa. Heroism lies not in a display of bravery but in refusing an unauthorised experiment. Nevertheless, a counter-position is required: continued waiting also increases delay in relief. The text makes this objection legitimate through the family's pain and the fatigue of the bodies involved. The decision therefore does not mean merely saying "no"; it also requires seeking the next safe stage of testing.

The transfer of patients who have already reached safety continues. A third bed's attendant tears her sandal, but arranges the patient's handover and care for her own foot in proper sequence. There is no dazzling display of vira rasa here, only the hard accounting of everyday clinical work. Three clocks before Rama give three different times; the start of the event, prohibition of entry, first contact, and first exit to the outside are recorded separately. This minute fragmentation of narrative time prevents the later formation of a predetermined story of blame. Artificially producing identical timings is not reasonable evidence. The novel's temporal craft shows clocks not as symbols of omniscient truth but as devices liable to error.

The Path of Voices: The Multi-layered Construction of Testimony

From inside, Devi reports to Salma only what she sees directly; Urmila puts off the request to move the bed until measurements arrive from outside. In an experiment using a thin rope to pass a piece of paper, three people prepare the reply together: the attendant writes, Urmila reads, and Devi makes corrections. This is not ordinary "testimony" but collaborative verification. The narrator makes the means of communication, the writing hand, and the final correction into separate scenes. Salma gives medical instructions from a distance without claiming full knowledge of the patient's condition. One form of distance is the incompleteness of voices, partly answered by linguistic care; that care cannot replace a safe route for the bed.

Naira records separate source markers for Urmila, Devi, and an indistinct voice further away. A cough is heard, but whose cough it was remains uncertain; refusing to register it against the patient's name maintains the distinction between observation and inference. The daughter asks where her mother is in all these papers. The implication of Naira's answer is that paper is not the mother; it is a means of preventing lies about the mother. The possible rigidity of an archival outlook is softened by this statement. Writing is not itself a replacement for life but a medium answerable for information about it. The speech of historically neglected women workers enters the record without becoming an all-seeing doctrine.

Even when Hira's boat and Gopal's knowledge of the water are available, rescue by carrying a boat up onto the hospital roof is not thereby possible. That simplification is dismantled twice. A bamboo pole from the boat may support a safe light, but it is not a tested prop for bearing weight. Hira accepts responsibility for moving supplies and evacuated people across the water at the designated landing; she does not undertake the removal of debris inside. The scene delineates the bounds of professional expertise. To regard a tool's usefulness in one place as a universal solution is a causal error. Water and environmental details recur, yet their decisional context differs each time. Here the boat opposes the impossible fantasy of a universal rescue machine.

Rukhsana does not stop serving food, but she records the additional wages due for work at night. An onlooker calls accounting at such a moment a sin; she replies that free meals and unpaid labour are not equivalent. The repetition of such episodes is also a formal risk: the novel repeatedly constructs ethical distinctions through explicit statements. Yet emergency assistance can turn into permanent exploitation, so the scene is not merely a manifesto. Creating a substitute list from a linen register without its washing marks and handover times produces alternative evidence in the face of a failure of documentation. Seeing a covering with a blue border is

not grounds for writing it under the wrong patient's name; the resemblance of objects is different from actual ownership.

Multiple Centres of Waiting, Medical Authority, and Public Information

Jamuna Devi's safe treatment continues. Salma distributes responsibilities and gives the wounded Aniruddha the task of handing over the correct medicinal supplies. Prestige attached to a medical post is not the same as the current capacity of a body. Seeing the numb hand of the assistant at the bed inside, Urmila has the load redistributed. The trapped people's bodies gradually bear the cost of time. Scene duration expands while material progress is slight: the narrative increases the detail of actions rather than the number of major events so that the reader experiences unbearable waiting. A story that appears stalled is not inactive. At every moment small events involving breathing, bandages, tools, measurement, and news occur. This is the chief artistic device of temporal duration.

A clerk asks how many names of the dead to write down. Rama immediately clarifies the difference between a death notice and the rescue register. She creates four categories: safely outside; injured and receiving treatment; in contact inside; status unconfirmed. The long memory of Sarita's original, mistaken death entry is effective here. Narratologically, the death of a specified person is a proposition to be established; lack of contact or invisibility through dust is not its necessary reason. "In contact" does not establish lasting safety, just as "status unconfirmed" does not establish the contrary fact of death. The appropriateness of the categories lies in the possibility of updating the record when conditions change.

For the third time the daughter asks how long rescue should take over a "distance of two rooms." Naira concedes that they can measure the length but not the time required to negotiate the collapsed beam, earth, and a safe exit for the bed. The daughter does not want "a false clock." The reader's appetite for information collides here with a family member's endurance; stating the truth is not always equivalent to providing immediate consolation. Tara looks at an open gap in the structure and says that an aperture visible to the eye is not a passage for a bed. A trained team receives permission to inspect, not to lift the load. A young man proposes a bold entry on his own; Tara points out the difference between the width of his body and the unseen overhead load. The dialogue conveys ethical restraint, although some characters speak too formulaically; the real urgency of prompt rescue might have been explored more deeply within that conflict.

Before approaching Naira, Kabir asks where it is safe to speak. He does not publicise the false report that "all those trapped have been rescued"

without confirmation from Rama. Naira relays the reply from inside that no new route has yet been approved as safe. Nor is the possible medicinal or consolatory use of a family member's tin of cloves determined without Salma's advice. The tin's presence is resonant: the daughter's olfactory memory, the bodily crisis of breathing, and clinical authority meet in one place. Calling out a name is possible, but there is no reply from the elderly woman. This particular absence is recorded without converting it into a final verdict on life. Domestic memory does not replace treatment, but preserves the character's personal history.

The Artistic Achievement of Extended Time and the Story's Incompletion

At the chapter's end, people who have already reached safety answer when their names are called; the trapped patient and Urmila's team answer from inside; no viable route for actual exit has been created. The juxtaposition of these two states gives Sauptika Parva its particular ethical effect: it honours partial successes without erasing what remains unsuccessful. Rama records each correction separately: the full identification of an initially incomplete name and replacement of a medicine that reached the wrong bed. Correcting a small error does not resolve the larger crisis, but may be decisive for a survivor's life.

Focalisation extends from Naira's pen to the suffering of Devi and Urmila inside, the daughter's waiting, Hira's landing place, Rukhsana's kitchen, and Rama's records. The narrator creates multiple voices, but many of them use the same cautious language of evidence; this uniformity of expression is a possible artistic limitation. The recurrence of "two rooms" intensifies the experience of waiting, though repeating the argument about distance in numerous dialogues can occasionally make the pace feel static. Yet within that apparent stasis there is a deliberately constructed irresolution. The present outcome is that some patients have been safely received; contact continues; a new point for inspection has been identified; and no human exit has been authorised. Even if readers know of a dreadful later event, it would be a critical error to fill this chapter's time with imagined knowledge of Urmila's or Naira's death or rescue.

Chapter 120 — Before Dawn

From the Justice of Updated Measurements to Sudden Failure

"Before Dawn" begins with the previous chapter's blank entry under "received outside." The edge of the wet paper has swollen. Naira has recorded the time of the last distinct voice, but her pen stops as she awaits further news. The safe markings established throughout the night are not permanent. Naira explains to a new worker that if the markings change, she will move as well. The responsible choice of Chapter 117 and the incomplete evacuation of Chapter 119 meet in this beginning. The story does not implant certain foreknowledge of a future disaster in the mind of any single heroine. A new material failure may occur despite useful inspection, precautions, and vigilance: that is the disquieting question of this final Sauptika chapter.

Tara sees a new line and the inclination of the jammed beam. Aditi gives the trained team permission to begin putting a support in place, not to bring out the bed trapped inside. Salma maintains the proper order of clinical questions while Aniruddha checks the names and quantities of necessary medicines. The limitations of a position repeatedly come into view: a doctor cannot enter without proof of a safe load that remains unknown; a boatman cannot provide structural support for the building's roof; a news writer cannot record the outcome of treatment. The advantage of this division of labour is that crisis management does not depend upon a lone heroic act. The critical risk is that the narration sometimes resembles a guide to collective operations; the subsequent unforeseen accident subjects this confidence in orderly arrangements to a severe test.

The trapped elderly woman's daughter keeps the same tin of cloves; Sarita tells her only as much as the currently confirmed information allows. Kabir does not claim a husband's special right to cross the forbidden line. Driver Haricharan insists that an exhausted driver be given food and rest; Gomati asks an additional worker to manage the cable for safe lighting. Such small actions keep the team outside alive and capable of work. The common principle of the chapter's first half is that injuries caused by failed arrangements for service must not be aggravated through further thoughtless attempts at service.

For the first time Urmila plainly admits that pain has spread through her arm from shoulder to fingers. Her disclosure at Devi's request marks a real inner change in the narrative of women's labour. She begins to move toward recognising her body as something more than a tool for holding a bed. Rukhsana's night-time khichri, Kanchan's bowl, and the accounts of

extra wages enlarge this remaining sense of life. At this moment the reader's emotion is not predetermined grief but the incomplete possibility of rest and treatment for a weary worker.

The Sequence of Broken Contact: Heard, Seen, Unseen

Aditi gives Naira a new instruction to move half an arm's length back from the outer inspection point. Naira changes position and does not return to the dangerous spot in the temptation to retrieve the corner of her notebook. Kabir writes in his own notebook Naira's last directly observed position and the words "contact available." These two items of evidence in the sequence matter. A local decision has been made on the basis of inspection, not a leap founded upon divine warning or destiny. A subsequent accident will not automatically establish that the earlier decision was negligent; it is necessary to examine the information and measurements of risk available when that decision was taken. Without this ethical distinction, criticism would fall into the reverse reasoning of proving an earlier crime merely from a later result.

A metallic sound is heard from inside. Someone thinks a new piece may have shifted there, but direct observation is impossible. Urmila reports new falling material, and Naira passes the message unaltered to Aditi. Tara opposes further entry because the overhead load remains uncertain; Aditi writes "entry suspended." Then comes the first loud sound, and a corner of the outer upper eave breaks off. Naira attempts to move back within the safe markings; a dense cloud of dust rises. Kabir hears her cry "Everyone back," but does not see her exact position. After a second sound the light goes out and debris obscures the spot where Naira had newly marked her position. Three facts are separate here: a warning was heard, debris was seen, and the person was not seen directly. None of these is complete evidence of the others.

A wet page from the register floats in the water and reaches the rescue team. Receiving the page tells them nothing about the condition of Naira's body. The recognisable voices of Devi, Urmila, and the assistant inside also stop; no answer comes to Salma's agreed signal. Salma says, "No signal has been received," refusing both conjectures that "everyone died" and that "everyone was rescued." Three members of the outside watch are counted, one injured. Naira is not found, and it remains unclear whether the phone was actually heard ringing or whether only an indicator was noticed. Exceptional caution is necessary in distinguishing these categories: loss of contact, absence from direct view, a directly witnessed death, and a death officially declared are four different things. The original chapter supplies evidence of only the first two; the third and fourth are not yet available.

Tara withdraws the earlier safe markings following the new collapse. This decision does not automatically make the earlier inspection's findings false; the scope and time of the information have changed. In narrative analysis of the subject of a proposition, "a load safe at a specified time" carries a temporal delimitation of what is to be established. Treating it as timeless safety is improper, but neither is it proven that all previous testing was deceptive simply because a later calamity occurred. The critic must be especially careful here: investigation of actual structural defects and responsibility will follow, but the present text does not give a final determination of causation. The immediate response to the new damage is to prevent more accidents, not to proclaim guilt.

The Names of the Missing: Grief, Rumour, and Archival Restraint

The patient's daughter asks Kabir about Naira and Urmila. Kabir reports the truth about Naira's last observed position and the broken contact, not a promise that she has reached the outside safely. An unconfirmed message arrives on a volunteer's phone saying that Urmila has survived and Naira is returning home. Kabir challenges it by asking for eyewitnesses, a rescuer, and the time of confirmed arrival. False hope too can have a violent effect, for it may alter a family's decisions and preparation for grief. Refusing to write assurances on the strength of love is not a triumphant moral victory for Kabir but a difficult restraint. The characters' acknowledged ignorance becomes a counterpoint to the unreliable digital flow of the narrative.

Rama makes four columns: directly received outside, previously in voice contact, contact broken, and independent confirmation pending. It is painful to put Naira's and Urmila's names under "contact broken," but that does not mean recording two deaths. Sarita's old, false death entry becomes ethically relevant again. In the novel's opening, declaring the living Sarita dead in a register gave rise to injustice; now an untrue assurance that someone has survived must likewise be rejected. The prohibition has two important directions: do not write a false death, and do not falsely confirm life either. A person's dignity is safeguarded by making the limits of truthful knowledge explicit. Within the story, a "name" is not material for counting or sensationalism but a distinct obligation toward every unfinished life.

The injured guard's statement confirms that a warning was heard, not that he saw Naira's position. After checking with Rama, Salma, and Aditi, Kabir writes a brief public notice, leaving the count of safely received people blank until confirmed. Such scant information cannot itself rescue anyone, but it lessens the danger of families rushing toward the forbidden line in pursuit of unverified news. The account openly acknowledges the limit of the record's usefulness: paper cannot remove debris. Kanchan says to Rukhsana that the water kept ready for Naira has grown cold; Rukhsana

asks her to keep it covered. This household object is a powerful suggestion of pain, but cooling water is not a secret code announcing death. The novel creates anguish without imposing the outcome on the reader.

The Final Structure of Sauptika's Darkness: What Incompletion Means

In the final passage Tara and Aditi draw a new boundary, the trained team prepares inspection instruments and lights, and Gomati records the workers' safe wait. Rather than the eastern sky, the yellow glow of a relit lamp provides the first indication of dawn. Even this light does not establish knowledge: entry into the debris remains undecided. Kabir looks on his phone at an earlier message from Naira—"We have just heard a voice; no final conclusion yet"—whose moment has already passed. He writes a new line: "Contact lost; awaiting the next direct confirmation." This is the most subtle point of narrative time: an entry true at one moment must be updated at another, but it is improper to fill a final blank without new facts. The plot remains incomplete, yet its ethical understanding is not incomplete.

The chapter's pattern of images is made from lamp, wet page, dust, and an unstable line. Light is not the seat of knowledge but a means of re-examination; water remains life-giving even as it increases structural danger; a line provides order but has to change constantly with circumstances. The narrator shifts focalisation among Naira's markings, Kabir's newly written entry, Salma's medical uncertainty, Sarita's ethical memory, and Rukhsana's labour. The reader's anticipation becomes intense, yet there is no imagined "death scene." In the ancient night of Sauptika, named and unnamed people really are murdered; to declare the uncertain disappearances at the close of this modern night to be definite deaths would be an intertextual excess.

The achievement is that the crisis has been protected against sensational verdicts and turned into the difficult discipline of preserving evidence. The limitation is that character after character gives nearly the same warning against "unproved inference," at times reducing the differences among their inward voices. A more fragile and inconsistent stream of consciousness could have been developed within the waiting daughter, Kabir's private terror, and Sarita's memories. Yet the blank space for confirmation of arrival, the withdrawal of an unverified report, and the new light make the closing scene effective. The conclusion is this: **contact is lost with Naira and with Urmila's team at two distinct locations; a new structural failure has occurred; a fresh inspection for rescue is beginning; this chapter provides no direct confirmation that they are dead or have reached safety.** The mourning narrative of the ensuing Stri Parva / Yuddha

Kanda will begin from this point, but to insert its later knowledge here would not constitute faithful criticism.

Sauptika Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Overall Critical Assessment of Chapters 109–120

The First Four, Middle Four, and Final Four: Work, Evidence, and Broken Contact

The first quartet of Sauptika Parva (109–112) establishes the night-time five-signature arrangement, controlled supplies from the warehouse, the boat's capacity, and the responsibilities of knowledge and labour. The middle quartet (113–116) places the avenging darkness of Ashwatthama's ancient night attack in an opposing ethical direction to rescue in the modern hospital, medicine, restricted consent for video use, and the prohibition on entering the old wing. In the final quartet (117–120), the narrative reaches the practical testing of a safe route chosen within known limits, then stops with an unfortunate new collapse and lost contact at two locations. The new section does not render earlier successful relief arrangements meaningless; rather, it teaches the reader to acknowledge successful evacuations and the uncertain situation of those trapped at the same time. Actual event density cannot be calculated merely from the narrative's "markers of change per thousand words": the cause, consequence, remaining risk, and independent confirmation of each change must be examined separately.

The Reconstruction of Time and the Limits of the Narrator's Knowledge

Although the sequence of day and night is linear in this parva, the experience of narrative time is fragmented. Night watches, differing hospital clocks, the register at the information desk, replies received along a thin rope, and an old phone message all construct story-time from distinct forms of evidence. The finding established by the inspection at 8:47 in Chapter 117 is delimited by the new dampness of Chapter 118. In Chapter 119 the remaining distance of two rooms turns into an uncertainty about time; in Chapter 120 the moment for which an earlier report was current has passed, requiring a new entry for incomplete contact. The distinction between "time observed" and "time stated" becomes a central theoretical question. The reader knows that bodily events have occurred, but the narrator never gives characters holding incomplete evidence definite future outcomes. The critic, too, must respect this limit of knowledge.

The narrator is acquainted with multiple consciousnesses in the third person, but inequalities of focalisation remain. Naira's notebook classifies situations; Urmila's tired hand speaks of bodily duration; Devi and Salma

have partial direct experience of breathing; the daughter lives the time of waiting; Kabir stands between public information and private terror. Because of this distribution of focalisation, the event cannot be reduced to a lone hero's story or a mere institutional report. Inner emotional movement receives limited representation at points, while the sheer number of external objects and dialogues sometimes makes the voices of different characters sound alike.

Narrative Evidence, Classical Intertext, and the Rejection of Unauthorised Conclusions

The distinctions among direct observation, verbal testimony, a temporal record, and inference constitute the principal evidentiary values of this parva. "A boat is ready" does not mean "rescue on the roof is possible"; "an empty bed completed the turn" does not mean "every patient is safe"; "no voice replied" does not mean "death has occurred"; and "an accident followed an earlier decision" does not mean "the earlier inspection was deliberately fraudulent." In reconstructing these arguments, distinctions of paksha, sadhya, hetu, upadhi, and time-specific delimitations are useful. They are analytic tools employed by the critic, not a claim that all these formulae are uttered by the original characters in a formal philosophical disputation. It is also essential to distinguish acknowledgement of the limits of knowledge from evasion of responsibility: incomplete information does not mean inactivity, but safe action within available limits.

In the Mahabharata's Sauptika Parva, night becomes the occasion for a violent attack; in the modern night the rescuers try to protect people who are trapped. The inverted parallel is powerful, though a simple dualism has its limitations. The ancient scene's use of modern ethical language sometimes reduces the historical distinction between its characters; modern relief work likewise still demands investigation of errors, improper delays, and institutional weaknesses. A broad conception of crossing boundaries and carrying evidence may connect the episode with the Ramayana's Sundara Kanda, but Chapters 117–120 contain no independent ancient scene. The recognition of intellectual labour associated with Bhāmati, the question of unseen causation associated with Nyāyakusumāñjali, and the discipline of evidence associated with Tattvacintāmaṇi provide useful conceptual connections for criticism. One must avoid claiming that every character's decision is a translation of propositions in those original classical treatises.

Women's Labour, Technical Authority, and Videha Parallel History

Urmila's linen register, Gomati's watch, Tara's and Sugni's measurements, Salma's clinical decisions, Rukhsana's kitchen, Hira's boat, Tulsi's drivers,

Rama's archives, and Naira's information work all call upon different skills. The work refuses to dissolve women's service into the supposedly natural, unpaid emotion of caring. Rest, wages, safe work, confidentiality, private memory, the family's right to information, and training become subjects of social history. Because of this many-part labour, the "five signatures" are not merely a story about the five signatories; many unnamed assisting hands stand behind them. From the perspective of Videha parallel history, local memories, silt in the drain, washing records, the load on a boat, and payments due to families form a counter-position to the state's one-dimensional document of victory.

Nevertheless, criticism cannot consist of praise alone. Repeatedly explicit statements of boundaries make dialogue excessively regulatory; an abundance of timed forms impedes the emotional tension of particular episodes; and across sections one encounters recurrent propositions such as "help is different from wages," "paper is different from a body," and "prohibition is different from cruelty." The rational voices of women working with technology could have been developed through finer distinctions of class and speech. The anguish of family members often occupies less space than the balanced replies of experts. The concrete material description of the new collapse corrects this abstract tendency, but does not eliminate the problem altogether.

From Sauptika to Stri Parva: The Empty Space Beside a Name

The final truth of Chapter 120 is not proof that anyone has died but **the severing of contact and an empty space in the register of confirmations**. The problem that arose in Chapter 1, "The Dead Woman's Kitchen," when the living Sarita was incorrectly declared dead returns in a new and more painful form: this time, haste to declare a person alive also carries risk. The last directly observed scene, last voice heard, new debris, damaged structure, unconfirmed phone report, and the assisting team's safe inspection must each be recorded separately. The ensuing chapters of Stri Parva will examine actual confirmation of death, the guilt of survivors, grief, and the circumstances of treatment. Writing their outcomes in advance into this earlier section would violate both the chronology of the narrative and its discipline of evidence. The artistic essence of Sauptika Parva is neither "precautions are useless" nor "precautions will save everyone": decisions are time-dependent, knowledge is limited, and responsibility toward every individual and their name persists even amid uncertainty.

Stri Parva / Yuddha Kanda

Chapter 121 — Confirmation of Names

The Beginning of the Post-Crisis Period: From Absence to Irreversible Death

The narrative significance of "Confirmation of Names" lies not merely in the outcome of the information disclosed but in the time, labour, and psychological resistance through which the story passes between the "loss of contact" in the preceding Chapter 120 and the "confirmation of death" in this chapter. In the opening passage Rama wipes the brass bell but does not ring it. Ordinarily, the bell might serve to make a public announcement and gather people together; here its silence establishes the opening rhythm of the narrative. The reader is not first given the names of the dead. Instead, the text shows a secure point of access, the placement of supports, a trained team, and a route blocked since the previous night. This postponement is not a cheap device for prolonging suspense: the physical process of reaching knowledge about life and death becomes part of the narrative's internal structure. Thus the incomplete night scene of Sauptika Parva enters the dawn of Stri Parva.

The chapter's first event is the emergence of an injured rescue assistant alive. Immediately afterwards Naira's body is found. The order has structural significance: within the same collapsed building, the reader encounters both surviving and extinguished life. The attention given to the first person's injuries, consciousness, and ability to state their name makes Naira's scene harsher by contrast; yet the writer incorporates a process of identification even into that harshness. Kabir does not treat the colour of the clothing as conclusive. He correlates the face and an old, small mark with another record. "Naira did not survive": Kabir's brief sentence brings to a narrative close the dozens of anxious questions preceding it, but it does not summarise Naira's whole life. As an event in the story, this fact is irreversible; the grief and responsibility that follow remain open.

The proportions of narrative time deserve particular attention. Within a single day, from dawn to evening, thirty passages successively accommodate final news about several lives, the care of injured people, food, separate journeys by families, and the preservation of wet papers. Whenever concrete work alternates with slow dialogue, scene-time slows. The narrator does not end the story by announcing some omniscient conclusion on the same morning. The receipt of verified information, the endurance of that information, and the renewed recollection of the night's work and the needs of home occupy three different psychological durations. Their distinction transforms the title's seemingly fixed

administrative term, “confirmation,” into an unfolding human experience.

Multiple Centres of Perspective: Kabir, Sarita, Rama, and Urmila's Sister

The narrator tells the story in the third person, but the person whose inward thinking is approached most closely is not always the same. Before Kabir enters the identification room, his internal question—that once he has seen, he cannot make himself not have seen—brings the reader inside his fear. From Sarita's focal position, a memory returns of an earlier municipal meeting and the chair Naira moved aside for her. When focalisation shifts to Rama, the difference between lines in a register, the order of operations, and the public circulation of a voice come into view. In the scene involving Urmila's sister, the weight of the story falls not only upon the solitary weeping of kinship but also upon the recognition of a person's employment. Such shifts prevent the novel from dissolving all its women into one undifferentiated, tearful “collective grief.”

Sarita's remembered scene is a definite analepsis: it belongs to a municipal meeting before the present disaster. Naira's question—who will pay for the error?—and her movement of a chair at the table for Sarita make the irony of her present absence more acute. The writer does not define Naira solely by the scene of her death; instead, the narrative brings back the active choices of someone to whom society ought to have made room to speak while she lived. The meaning of this memory is important: going backwards in chronological time becomes a means of advancing the narrative. Sarita now accepts Naira's absence, but she does not consider that absence equivalent to “striking out her name.” This objection creates a long recurrence reaching back to the first chapter's erroneous report of Sarita's death while she was alive. The life-truth of the two reports is not the same.

The discovery of a wet register page alongside Urmila's body generates a particularly important reversal of narrative expectation. The reader might expect the paper to establish her identity immediately; the plot, however, relies first upon the body, medical examination, and identification accepted by the family. Her sister has the full name “Urmila Rajak” recorded and points out the inadequacy of calling her merely “the hospital washerwoman.” At the opening of Stri Parva, this is not a social detail alone. The “name” of the chapter's title acquires several layers of occupation, family, and self-respect. In a conventional lament the name may become the deceased person's final identification; here Urmila's unpaid wages become a question left over from her life.

Recurring Objects, Understatement, and the Incompleteness of Grief

The brass bell, Naira's telephone, the wet page, cooked rice, Urmila's clothing receipt, and Subhadra's medicine form a kind of small-scale chain of objects from beginning to end. Their recurrence is not merely an elaboration of symbolism: each has a distinct practical use, domestic association, and social meaning. Kabir does not repeatedly unlock Naira's phone; later he finds in it a list concerning salt, the repair of books, and Naira's home. Here the mobile phone is not simply a medium for digital news but a remnant of private continuity. It enables the reader to understand that death does not immediately cancel the ordinary list of unfinished tasks that made up a life.

Rukhsana's kitchen avoids the stock image of "offering food as consolation" in bereavement. Kanchan does not repeatedly compel Urmila's sister to eat; instead, she asks for half a bowl for the child. This small exchange registers a delicate change of circumstances in place of an extended sentimental speech. The narrator does not elevate the act by calling it a great sacrifice. The availability of food, the right to refuse it, and a child's hunger remain on separate levels. Understatement of this kind produces karuna rasa, the aesthetic mood of compassion, but the principal analytical question concerns narrative restraint: how can the writer's language remain affecting without overwhelming the scene?

At the end of the chapter, three sealed envelopes and one incomplete line of personal identification are kept separate. Within the story the deaths of Naira, Urmila, and an elderly female patient have been confirmed, but the name of another elderly man remains unresolved. Such differentiation gives the narrative the form of grief arriving in stages: the final news received by one family does not ensure certainty about another's future. In the closing sentence, boiling water in the kitchen returns beside the red line marking prohibition. The next tasks of living coexist with the remains of danger. "Confirmation" marks the ending of a chapter, not the resolution of the disaster as a whole.

Artistic Achievement, Balance of Voices, and Limitations

The chapter's chief achievement is to establish a distance between hearing news of death and writing the story of a death. The sequence of scene, summary, and analepsis within the modern hospital events is deliberate. Pauses, unfinished sentences, and brief replies express the characters' exhausted consciousness. The female characters do not speak in a single voice of "self-sacrifice": Sarita speaks the language of relationships; Rama changes the boundaries of classification; Urmila's sister preserves a ledger of wages; Rukhsana offers a choice of food; Devi Gond enumerates several reasons for her own survival. The basis of polyphony, therefore, is not

simply an abundance of dialogue but the differing powers of decision exercised by different people.

Nevertheless, the reader may maintain a critical distance. In the novel, many characters articulate the limits of their own claims at precisely the appropriate moment. Statements by Rama, Salma, Gomati, Aditi, and others can repeatedly sound like unusually self-aware editorial cautions. Greater space for the sudden, broken, or disordered language of bodies in crisis might make the difference between psychological fragmentation and institutional composure more immediately felt. Likewise, the artistic decision to keep the intensity of pathos moderate protects Naira's death from sensationalism; yet the uninterrupted succession of carefully reasoned objections can sometimes diminish the felt disorder of grief's own time. This is a possible limitation to be weighed in the light of different readers' experiences, not an accusation without evidence.

Chapter 122 — The Last Body

Not a Name but Uncut Cloth: The Narrative Arrangement of Waiting

In this chapter, the uncertainty surrounding the identity of the dead, rather than a definitive death notice, drives the narrative. On the mortuary veranda, a half-open white cloth, Shashibhushan Mahapatra's measuring cord, and four envelopes constitute the first scene. Although three of the deceased have been identified through separate processes, the name of the fourth body remains suspended. The title "The Last Body" may lead the reader to expect that "at last a name will be found," but the chapter ends at a deliberately undecided point. This reversal of expectation is joined to the book's ethical question: is it right to write an incorrect final sentence merely to bring somebody's life-story to completion?

Narrative time advances from Chapter 121. Here a day's progression—dawn on a damp veranda, families arriving before noon, separate turns in the identification room, a revised list in the afternoon, uncut cloth at evening—is divided into small temporal units. The absence of a final result is not a negative void in the plot; it is itself a different kind of change. Initially there was pressure to fill the fourth line with a conjectured name. At the end, that line reads "identification in progress." The state of affairs in the story has changed, even though the original question persists. The narrative thus does not cease to move; instead, the meaning of "resolution" changes.

Shashibhushan's work of cutting cloth functions as a precise metaphor grounded in action. Once cloth measured for a purpose has been cut, it cannot be restored to its former state; the definitive imposition of an individual's name on an unidentified body can likewise multiply social

difficulties. Yet the cloth does not become an abstraction detached from the ground. Shashibhushan keeps actual accounts of the wages owed to the weaver, carrier, and assistant. The distinction between having the material ready and cutting the final garment arises from the character's occupational knowledge. Here "the last body" signifies not a universal metaphysics of mortality but the preservation of time and space for a person whose identity remains undecided.

Parallel Families, Distinct Stories, and Focalisation

Unclear letters on the slips carried by two families—suggesting names such as "Budhan Das" and "Budhan Paswan," together with a different possibility, "Budhan Sah"—create the identification problem. The narrative does not construct an easy opposition in which one family is lying and the other tells the truth. Sabita is under pressure to recognise her father-in-law's body first; another elderly woman is searching for signs of her husband. Both women want an identification, yet both withdraw from making a decisive claim. The parallel construction shows that more than one possible story can inhabit the same scene. The novel questions the impatience of the reader who wants a name to be chosen.

Alongside the uncertain name, clues provided by objects increase the potential for confusion: the colour of a dhoti, an empty spectacle case, the knot in a bag, an incomplete letter, wristband numbers "472" and "427," blue thread, and a blurred photograph on a mobile phone. The task here is not to turn the scene into a forensic manual. The narratological question concerns how the writer gradually enlarges and then restricts the reader's information. Each object raises the hope that "the solution has now appeared," only for its insufficiency to leave the scene open. The distribution of information remains tied to a character's experience: a nurse can describe the colour of the cot she saw, but while bodies were being carried her attention was upon another patient's breathing. The narrator does not make an omniscient leap to fill that gap.

Sabita's sentence—if I return the wrong name, I shall steal another household's grief—is an especially concentrated linguistic centre of the chapter. The phrase "stealing grief" conveys a social trespass: the intensity of one's own bereavement cannot confer the right to obliterate somebody else's relationship. Sabita therefore leaves the identification room without a definite answer, and the other elderly woman likewise refuses to turn inward longing into a final decision. The narrative presents the two women's uncertainty not as weakness but as a respected choice of character. This is a concrete example of the plural structure of grief in Stri Parva.

The Recurrence of Objects: Cloves, Yellow Cloth, Keys, and an Untied Knot

The box of cloves from Chapter 121 returns here. The elderly patient's daughter has emptied it, but she chooses a light-yellow cloth for her mother. The same colour summons a small memory from their earlier domestic life: a scene in which the mother taught her younger daughter to sew clothes for a doll. The reader is thereby invited to see the elderly woman as more than "an identification safely established outside the fourth line" of a register. A minute object-symbol stands in for an extension of life, but the memory depicted remains limited: the narrator does not confidently specify how many years earlier the incident occurred.

The key to the washing ghat and the ledger of unpaid wages in Urmila's sister's hands constitute another account of continuing labour. Shashibhushan's receipts for materials are kept separate from Urmila's work ledger. The narrative function of this double accounting is that the scene of death cannot serve as an ending that erases the unfinished occupational pages of a person's life. The strands concerning the rights and labour of artisans, developing since Chapters 37–48, remain active even after death. This recurrence opens a path for the reader to reread earlier chapters; it does not merely introduce a new incident.

Shashibhushan's final piece of uncut cloth and the fourth knot "left open" form a powerful closing image. In conventional narration, tying a knot can suggest closure or resolution. Here, deciding not to tie it makes visible the refusal to fix an incorrect name upon an unidentified person. The narrator explains the import of this object-image more than once. Its own force might have allowed the reader to reach the conclusion without repeated explanation; for some readers, the reiteration may be unnecessary. Nevertheless, the uncut cloth's emergence as a memorable visual image partly mitigates that risk of repetition.

Scene-Rhythm, Prolonged Hesitation, and Critical Limitations

The action in this chapter is comparatively slow, but the tension of the scenes is intense. Families enter, look, decline to decide for the moment, and go outside; an official revises the list; Shashibhushan sets cloth aside. These repeated actions detach the time of bereavement from the pressure of "the date of the funeral." The narrative style proceeds through a clearly edited sequence of dialogues in which Sabita, the other elderly woman, Rama, Shashibhushan, Kabir, Salma, and Devi each speak from the limits of their own experience. The narrative recurrence of "do not write a name on conjecture" takes several forms. The object of study is not whether the principle is right or wrong, but whether its repetition creates emotional depth or slows the narrative rhythm.

A possible weakness of the chapter is that administrative dialogue begins to carry almost the whole burden of explaining the circumstances of many people. Rama often states directly the meaning that the narrator wants the reader to draw; Shashibhushan becomes her ethical counterpart. The halting emotions of the two families, a minor's spectacle case, and the uncertain story of a half-written letter could have sustained a more extended independent development. The novel leaves all these experiences incomplete. On the one hand this is an artistic courtesy; on the other, it limits the time the reader spends with the complexities of the distinct families' life histories. Only by considering these two aspects together can an impartial assessment become possible.

Chapter 123 — Gandhari's Question

A Turn in the Temporal Stream: From the Modern Mortuary to a Mother's Voice on the Battlefield

From the modern medical setting of Chapters 121–122, the third chapter suddenly moves into the morning after the Mahabharata war. This is not merely an epic allusion achieved by putting a familiar name in the title, "Gandhari's Question." It is an entirely independent ancient time-stream, inhabited by Gandhari, Dhritarashtra, Sanjaya, Duhshala, Draupadi, Yudhishthira, Krishna, and numerous unnamed families. The change establishes two different temporal axes: the uncertain name of a fourth body in the modern hospital and the uncertain news of death received by many families on the ancient battlefield. The relation between these two temporal structures is one of narrative resonance, not direct equivalence between persons. Sarita is not Gandhari reborn, nor is the modern nurse a counterpart of Sanjaya. Narratives belonging to different periods allow each other's questions to be heard in new circumstances.

The opening scene begins with two broken seams in Gandhari's veil and the tightness of her blindfold. The blindfold is associated with Gandhari's familiar identity, but the novel does not turn it into an unchanging emblem: she herself decides how tightly it should be tied. A remark to the effect that it is "not meant to darken sorrow" opens up the independence of her consciousness. The next scene presents the ornamented sash belonging to Duryodhana's wife: questions of power in wartime are compressed into an unfinished piece of domestic sewing. The contrast of scale between the destruction of an outward empire and a small inward object is the chapter's principal technique. Gandhari's focal position continually exceeds the category of "queen mother."

The chapter's present narrative time covers one day after the war has ended. The chariot journey, the field, the encounters with different

families, and the departure before evening follow a broadly forward-moving chronology. Yet memories of Gandhari's sons in childhood and of Duryodhana's wife's domestic life split this time from within. The narrative does not retell the last moments of the war at length; it makes the time that remains after news of the war its principal subject. This choice raises the question of the "right to tell" the war, rather than merely presenting the war as an "event."

Polyphony: The Queen Mother, the Potter's Wife, Duhshala, a Newly Married Woman, and Draupadi

Gandhari changes the route of her chariot and asks a woman from a potter's family for the name of her son. The overturned potter's wheel, an unfinished pot, and the absence of the son who had gone to carry water form another narrative of labour destroyed by war. The woman does not bow before the queen mother; the novel receives her silence not as disrespect but as the expression of an independent grief. A simple sentence such as "He used to make pots" displaces the vocabulary of heroic chronicles: the person was not merely an auxiliary to a soldier but someone who possessed a life of craftsmanship. Gandhari hears his name from the woman herself; she does not compose a whole biography on the woman's behalf. Here polyphony signifies not just a greater number of spoken lines but the social relocation of a voice away from the royal centre.

Within her grief for her brothers, Duhshala chooses to meet the wife of a soldier who harnessed the horses of chariots. The husband's debt ledger and the question of earned wages make a general announcement of state assistance insufficient. This small subplot prevents Duhshala from being merely a "sister" of the Kaurava lineage; she determines her own journey, her own questions, and the time she will spend listening to another woman's answer. Draupadi and Gandhari speak across the divide created by deaths in their families about practical arrangements for cloth, water, wood, and the care of children. The two women's suffering is not identical, but the basis of their conversation is not the enemy's defeat: it is the needs of those who remain alive.

A newly married woman does not know whether her husband has died in battle or has been taken prisoner. Her undecided story forms a structural connection with the fourth body in Chapter 122. The reader remembers Sabita's hesitation in the preceding chapter; to evoke that memory the writer need not replay a modern scene. Such a distant echo activates the reader's narrative memory. Making time for an unnamed young wife amid the grief of royal houses broadens the meaning of the declared title, Stri Parva.

Focalisation and the Arrangement of Sound

Gandhari's blindfold plays a complex role in the novel's system of vision. The narrator shows the reader external sights—the open courtyard, the overturned potter's wheel, dust, and the victory banner. Gandhari's experience, however, is constituted through the sound of horses' hooves, the edge of a garment, people's footsteps, smell, and touch. Thus the narrator's knowledge and the principal character's sensory experience are not identical. The narrator is third-person; the main focal centre is Gandhari, although Duhshala's and the young wife's experiences also come forward temporarily. As a consequence, "darkness" does not automatically become a metaphor for ignorance. What lies beyond Gandhari's sight does not lie beyond her capacity to listen and question. This character-centred sensory arrangement is a notable achievement of the chapter's narrative craft.

The victory banner is folded away; it is decided that the bell of victory should ring in the assembly rather than at the cremation ground. This is a striking recurrence of an object from the silent bell in Chapter 121. In both places public sound is withheld or relocated, although the situations of the modern Rama and the ancient Gandhari differ. Linking the two passages, the reader formulates the question of "the right time to tell a story." This intertextual coordination creates narrative unity without asserting direct sameness.

The scene in which Gandhari touches Duryodhana's hard finger and her reply to Duryodhana's wife about keeping blame distinct from memory bring contrary feelings into the character's consciousness simultaneously. She neither erases her son's wrongdoing nor destroys memories of his childhood. In this mixed consciousness the character becomes considerably more complex than a one-dimensional "mother who pronounces a curse." The scene in which the language of a curse rises is likewise not simply an inevitable pronouncement about the future: the fierce language of grief runs together with questions of responsibility. Care is required not to equate the voice of the novel's own Gandhari scene with every interpretation of the traditional epic.

The Unanswered Question at the End and Literary Limitations

At the chapter's end Gandhari changes the direction of her chariot again, intending to return to the potter's wife's home and enquire after the children's food. In this way the scene from the beginning of the route recurs at its end. A decision to "meet again," rather than proclaim an "ultimate saga," closes the narrative arc without closing the questions raised by grief. An attendant resumes sewing the unfinished seam; this small scene of labour gives the opening object a meaningful circular

return. Questions left unanswered need not be regarded as evidence of a failed narrative. They may signal a society that remains incomplete.

There are artistic limitations as well. Almost every statement Gandhari makes is pure, balanced, and filled with ethical reflection. Although the statements of the young wife, Duhshala, and the potter's wife retain social differences, more linguistic bitterness, uncertainty, and unexpected emotional disturbance might have made the polyphony more vivid. In the scene with Yudhishthira, Gandhari's questions often predetermine the range of possible answers. The novel thus comes close, in several places, to turning its narrative questions into moral conclusions. Even so, its distinct domestic objects, smells, textures, and returning journeys lend subtle visual and sensory feeling to this tendency towards argument.

Chapter 124 — Inside Mandodari

From the Inner Palace to the City: The Extended Time and Space of Private Grief

"Inside Mandodari" is a chapter in the independent Lanka time-stream. It opens with a cracked bronze measuring vessel in the royal grain store and ends when an elderly water carrier asks for the way to her home in an open corridor of the royal residence. Between these places Mandodari passes through the inner palace, the market, blocked roads, the battlefield, and back to the grain store. Time is compressed into one day, but the extent of the social space gradually widens. It would be limiting to read "inside" in the title merely as a reference to a state of mind: when the story steps outside the palace, it reveals the labour, fear, and obstructed voices held within its enclosing walls.

News of Ravana's death first arrives as something heard; Mandodari's experience changes when she comes face to face with his body. This narrative pacing reveals the psychological distance between "news" of a death and an encounter with the dead body of a loved one. Trijata distinguishes available verified information about Sita's safety from hearsay. It would nevertheless be wrong to treat this time-stream as a direct institutional equivalent of a modern medical centre. The creative similarity lies in the way uncertain information continues to alter human relationships after a war. Mandodari's grief does not end when she sees Ravana's body; the scene divides her attention between memories of her past and concerns about the new government to come.

Mandodari declines the heavy crown and chooses a plain sari she has stitched herself. This change of clothing shifts focalisation from royal identity towards the private experience of her body. A phrase such as "It

knows my body" gives the garment the continuity of an intimate companion throughout her life, but it would be premature to describe this as complete political emancipation. Mandodari still possesses privileged access to the palace courtyard, the guards, and conversations with Vibhishana; she is not stopped at the gates as ordinary women are. The novel itself makes this inequality visible from scene to scene.

Mandodari's Consciousness: Memory, Regret, and Opposing Feelings

Before Trijata, Mandodari acknowledges an earlier silence: she passed up an opportunity to oppose a decision publicly in the royal assembly because fear of Ravana's anger and ridicule held her back. The narrator employs this admission as an analepsis. A brief scene from an earlier time complicates the present character's assertion that "I did oppose it." She herself recognises the difference between speaking privately and speaking in public. Thus the character refuses to construct a simple story of her own innocence; the possibility of self-criticism develops within her present conversation.

On the road of war, three women conjecture different relationships to the body of a soldier wearing a red thread. That sight awakens a memory of Meghnad's small wooden boat in childhood. The recollection produces a domestic temporality distinct from the heroic saga of battle: the little boy blamed the current of the canal, and his mother taught him to look at the bottom of the boat. Here the story does not present the past as the definitive truth of the "real Meghnad"; it gives us an experience of living affection from one time within Mandodari's consciousness. Later the loosened string of Ravana's veena calls forth a memory of his music. Through such memories the dead king ceases to be a fixed, wholly demonic or idealised heroic figure, without thereby being absolved of responsibility for his decisions.

Beside Ravana's body a minister proposes having a "suitable" heroic elegy written. The scene represents a struggle to control the voice of mourning. Mandodari possesses the right to speak both of her personal sorrow and of the consequences of Ravana's royal decisions. The significance of her reply is closely related to other chapters of Stri Parva. When Kabir prevented Naira's final message from becoming a public image, and when Urmila's sister demanded her full name, the modern scenes raised the question: who will write whose story? Mandodari's rejection of an official royal lament is a different cultural form of the same question. The similarity is neither a claim about identical souls nor historical continuity; it is a structural echo concerning narrative authority.

Secondary Characters and the Social Geography of Lanka

The elderly oil seller's half-blocked shop and weighing scales make visible losses outside the royal residence. She asks for news of her two sons, but Mandodari cannot give her an immediate answer. The woman's question and Mandodari's sorrow continue side by side towards the chapter's end. "The great people of the royal household" and the market woman do not merge into the same grief. The former bear the distinctions of state power; the latter faces risks to her livelihood. This separation makes Lanka more than Ravana's fortress: it becomes a city sustained by oil, chariots, water, grain, clothing, and memory.

A chariot maker's wife searching for a body, the daughter of a woman who cooks asking for her mother's tongs, a gardener's work of drawing water, and the kitchen elder's cracked measuring vessel together create the novel's expanded social scene. No person remains simply "a servant of the royal establishment." Someone needs a way home, someone needs her mother's ordinary tongs, another needs information about her husband, and still another needs enough vessels to distribute food. This succession of small wishes carries the narrative beyond the single victorious-versus-defeated centre of epic history. Mandodari's request that salvaged wood be reserved for rebuilding market homes becomes a tangible decision linking private sorrow with public loss.

Trijata marks the limits of the information she has concerning Sita. Mandodari acknowledges her earlier failure to secure Sita's release, but Sita is not obliged to listen to her. The dialogue does not reduce relationships among women to an uncomplicated sisterhood. Sympathy, responsibility, failure, and inequality in the right to be heard remain present. Mandodari's departure from the inner palace therefore describes not the completion of social change in a day, but the beginning of a number of small acts of listening.

The Repeated Opening Image and the Open Ending

The cracked measuring vessel of the first passage returns near the end. A new vessel is not available; the proposal is to bind the crack in the old one. Mandodari raises the question of whether the measure can be trusted to give a fair quantity. The image becomes a figure of Lanka's condition: a broken system cannot be repaired instantly by proclaiming it new; those who must use it need to examine both the damage and its continuing usefulness. The writer, however, often explains the significance of the image through what the character says. At some points greater trust in the silent scene would have preserved the image's openness.

On her return to the royal residence, the loose string of Ravana's veena forms a very small scene, yet becomes a subtle centre of the novel's

relationship to the past. The memory of Ravana playing music one night does not diminish Mandodari's right to oppose him in the present. Memory of love and criticism of injustice do not cancel one another; their tension generates the character's complexity. In the final passage, the gardener brings the omitted name of an elderly woman who carries water. Mandodari moves towards the open corridor to hear the question of how the woman may reach her home. The "inside" of the title is never confined to a private inner palace; in the final action, the narrative receives the voice of someone outside it.

A possible structural weakness of the chapter is that, after Ravana's death, many women, elderly people, soldiers, and attendants make similar social demands through brief scenes, nearly all pointing in the same direction. This can sometimes make Mandodari's opposition seem like an overly prepared programme of public policy, while the particular local roughness of people's speech becomes less audible. The three instructions to Vibhishana constitute concrete plot development, but the chapter does not show them being carried out: a written instruction and the successful arrival of an elderly woman at her home are two different narrative outcomes. By returning to the problem of an omitted name at the end, the writer ensures that a careless conclusion about "complete reform" would contradict the text itself. The chapter's human credibility also resides in this incompleteness.

Stri Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 121–124

Narrative Coherence: Two Modern Chapters and Two Independent Epic Scenes

The construction of this quartet is divided between two different places of grief, though both share an equally urgent ethical present. Chapters 121–122 follow a modern narrative stream of the collapsed hospital, mortuary, journeys by relatives, medicine at home, the kitchen, and registers of clothing and labour. Chapter 123 offers Gandhari's post-war journey, while Chapter 124 presents Mandodari's journey through Lanka as independent ancient scenes. The abrupt shift of period in the middle cannot be described merely as the insertion of a mythological example. This structural relocation compels the reader to view royal grief after war immediately after the grief of the modern disaster. Gandhari's folded victory banner and Mandodari's rejected heroic elegy question from a distance the modern journalist's request for a picture of the dead. Neither period "proves" the other; their narrative tensions give new meaning to one another.

The sequence of events in the first modern episode is loss of contact → discovery of a body → confirmation of death → grief and the work that remains. In the second it is confirmation of three names → uncertainty about the fourth → two families waiting → prevention of a false identification. Gandhari's episode proceeds from news of war → journey over the ground of the dead → autonomous testimony by several women → postponement of the victory announcement. Mandodari's episode moves from news of death heard from others → journey through a ruined city → encounter with Ravana's body → the question of an unnamed servant's right to go home. It would be inappropriate to fit these four sequences into a single pattern. Their diversity shows that a confirmed death is not necessarily the end of a story, and an uncertain name is not an absence of narrative substance.

Female Focalisation, Narrative Restraint, and Critical Conclusions

The women of these four chapters occupy different positions. Sarita remains alive with her vivid memories; Naira and Urmila are no longer bodily present, yet the effects of their work persist; Sabita and the other elderly woman live with uncertainty about identification; Gandhari hears the names of unnamed workers amid the grief of her dynasty; Mandodari acknowledges a history of fear in her own household. To call all these experiences one uniform "female suffering" would erase the story's social and psychological distinctions. Specific focalisations, scenes of recollection, object-images, and conversations give a separate form to each woman's choice.

The principal achievement is the expansion of time after bereavement. In a grieving society, cooking food, delivering medicine, feeding children, preserving the name attached to the dead person's work, measuring cloth, retaining the right to weep, and exercising the freedom to remain silent all continue. A possible artistic limitation, however, extends across the entire quartet: many characters explain the meanings of their statements too explicitly. Their language creates documentary decorum and ethical awareness, but can also contract the full independence of character voices, the disorder of anguish, and the interpretative space left open to the reader. The four chapters' powerful scenes organised around objects—the silent bell, uncut cloth, broken seam, and cracked measure—also provide a creative resistance to this explanatory tendency.

Chapter 125 — Kunti's Confession

The Moment of the Halted Offering: A New Beginning After the War's End

“Kunti's Confession” takes a day after the end of the war as its principal narrative present. The opening scene presents water spilling from a bronze lota on the Ganges ghat and Kunti's hand arrested in mid-air. Before it supplies information about the mystery of Karna's birth, it presents the bodily difficulty of speaking about it. Amid the continuous ritual actions of filling the vessel, offering water, and uttering names, the failure to pronounce one name becomes a disturbance in the plot. The blade of kusha grass in Yudhishthira's hand, the imagined tension of a drawn bowstring in Arjuna's mind, and the wet rim of Kunti's vessel are separate visual signs of the characters' mental states. The collective movement of mourning is halted to create space for an individual statement. Here the story-event and the process of telling become causes of one another: what was not said begins to alter the meaning of events already past.

The move from the ghat into the shade of a neem tree is more than a change of location. Passing from public death-rites into a smaller circle of listeners changes the level of narration. Kunti first asks her sons for an opportunity to hear her, but also asks Draupadi to remain, because the consequences of this concealed history have affected her life. The narrator places this choice between a woman's right to tell her own story and the right of another person affected by it. The facts surrounding Karna's birth may be familiar to the reader through memories of the Mahabharata; within this scene, however, the information reaches Yudhishthira, Bhima, Arjuna, Nakula, and Sahadeva suddenly. The gap between the reader's prior familiarity and the characters' ignorance generates dramatic irony: the reader knows that the disclosure of the name will reopen questions about the supposedly finished history of the war.

Delayed Disclosure and a Retrospective Narrative Order

Kunti's account opens three different doors into the past. The first concerns the birth before marriage and the memory of leaving the infant in the river; the second concerns her meeting with Karna before the war and her request that he spare four brothers among the five Pandavas; the third is the disturbing recollection of thread caught in the lid of the basket. These three analepses do not tell a complete biography in sequence. The first past opens up Kunti's fear and the unequal decisions of motherhood; the second reveals Karna's independent choice; the third, a memory of a physical thread, adds uncertainty and guilt to her confession. The narrator also preserves the uncertainty of recollection: Kunti cannot

remember precisely the colour of the light upon the infant's face. Accordingly, the flashback is not a retransmission of omniscient history, but a reconstruction of the past within an ageing character's present consciousness.

Arjuna's attention shifts from an elderly man splitting wood at the ghat to Karna's chariot wheel caught in the mud. The memory casts the decisive moment narrated earlier in the war in the light of a newly discovered relationship without undoing the action that actually took place. Arjuna acknowledges the impossibility of easily saying, after this revelation, "If I had known, I would have …" This counterfactual question offers a glimpse of an alternative story-world, but the writer does not convert that unrealised world into an event that definitely occurred. Yudhishthira, too, considers other possible courses for kingship and war but cannot state which choices would have changed. Such unresolved counterfactuality is an instance of the chapter's artistic restraint.

Grief with Multiple Centres: Five Brothers, Draupadi, and Radha's Household

Although the chapter's focalisation repeatedly returns to Kunti, it opens passages into the experience of people separate from her. Yudhishthira speaks the language of betrayed trust and the memory of the kingdom; Bhima is shaken by the entry of an unrecognised kinship into his understanding of his role in the war; Arjuna responds through a private recollection of a violent moment; Nakula and Sahadeva imagine Karna's life by way of questions about their own birth and home. All the brothers do not forgive their mother in one voice at one instant. Without these different reactions, the new knowledge about Karna's birth might have remained a single dramatic "revelation." The story creates a separate rhythm of change within each relationship.

Draupadi's presence is especially important. She does not forget the wounds inflicted by Karna's conduct in the royal assembly, even as she recognises Kunti's right to speak the truth of his birth. Later, amid her grief for her five dead sons, she also expresses her inability to determine immediately the meaning of a newly discovered relationship to an elder brother. The chapter therefore does not make revelation of birth equivalent to complete moral rehabilitation. Karna's misfortunes, his courage, earlier bitterness, and Draupadi's humiliation remain mutually uncomfortable elements of one story-world. Kunti does not force Draupadi to accept her confession. The narrative takes an intertextual character beyond a fixed ideal designation and protects a space for disagreement.

The entrance of an elderly relative from Karna's foster family, on the left side of the ghat, shifts the narrative centre away from the royal lineage.

The demand that the birth mother's story must not devour the years of upbringing by Radha and Adhiratha keeps several parallel life-histories of the same person in view. The elderly woman does not immediately offer Kunti either belief or consolation. The royal declaration and the foster family's private offering of water proceed separately. Many hands hold water in the name of one person, but not with one feeling. This polyphony also resonates narratively with the birth-and-upbringing issues raised earlier in Chapters 85 and 94; there is no need to treat the modern characters as mythological counterparts.

The Lota, Water, and the Symbolic Action of Leaving Space

The spilled water of the opening changes, at the end, into water at deep dusk, an emptied vessel, and the possibility of filling it for others. This circular image of an object gives the chapter formal unity. Yet water is not merely an abstract metaphor for motherhood or purification: rites of mourning, bodily exhaustion, slippery steps at the ghat, the labour of attendants, and separate offerings by many families are all bound to it. At the end Kunti accepts an attendant's support and leaves the lota empty. Her action indicates not a complete victory of confession but a waiting for other people's replies. Her wish to seek permission before visiting Radha's household marks a new practice opposed to her unilateral decision at the beginning of the story. Nevertheless, Radha's own detailed answer is not heard in this chapter; her voice enters indirectly through an elderly relative. This can be regarded as a formal shortcoming alongside the achievement of including her household.

For the reader the principal experience is less “a hidden truth has been found” than “how will time continue after the truth has emerged?” Kunti leaves the ghat without receiving any promise of forgiveness. Bhima's refusal does not amount to a complete severance of the relationship; Arjuna's question reaches no immediate conclusion; the silence of Radha's household leaves a further narrative open. The incomplete ending accords with the genuinely many-layered time of grief.

Narrative Achievements and Critical Limitations

The chapter's chief achievement is to remake a familiar epic revelation through memory, time, multiple listeners, and inward disagreement. The distribution of knowledge about birth, Draupadi's objection, the foster household's separate ritual, Arjuna's unresolved counterfactual, and Kunti's limited closure together construct Karna as a character with many overlapping lives. Nevertheless, much of the dialogue is expressed in highly coherent explanatory language: almost every character states the subtle moral limits of a relationship in nearly complete sentences. A fuller presence of broken speech or unorganised astonishment after the war

might have made certain scenes more vivid. The absence of Radha's direct, independent voice also points to the surviving dominance of the royal centre. Despite these limits, the chapter ends not with the solution of a mystery of birth but with a redistribution of the right to tell the story. That is its distinctive narrative identity.

Chapter 126 — The Measure of Rice

The Third Measure: The Non-Occurrence of an Event as a Narrative Subject

Immediately after the ancient royal revelation at the Ganges ghat, “The Measure of Rice” opens with a brass bowl in a modern kitchen. Both chapters begin with hands close to water; but in Chapter 125 a hand arrests the utterance of a name during a ritual offering, whereas in Chapter 126 it fails to stop a third measure of rice. Sarita puts the dead Naira's portion into the pot while following her daily habit of cooking a familiar quantity. In this unintended action, grief appears not as a grand declaration but as a bodily habit. Setting out a third plate, deciding how to use the remaining rice, and leaving uncertain whether tomorrow morning's measure will be reduced form the chapter's central arc of ordinary actions. A plot diagram might indicate that public external events are few; inward choices and relationships to memory, however, change continuously. To call this absence of events would be to misunderstand the chapter's artistic design.

In the first three passages, the pot, its cracked lid, the sewing machine, and a customer's kurti create a small configuration of time and space. Naira's old warning, “You will draw blood,” rises in Sarita's recollection, but the narrator makes it clear that the voice is not physically present. Because of this clarification, an experience in a grieving consciousness does not turn into a miraculous supernatural occurrence; the distinction between a voice heard inwardly and outward silence is preserved. The stationary wheel of the machine, the unfinished kurti, and the customer's measurements are contrasting signs of time: the world's work has not stopped although Sarita's pace of work has changed. After death, time cannot automatically proceed in its old rhythm. The novel renders this imbalance visible through domestic objects.

Multiple Analepses: Naira's Several Living Selves

Brief analepses repeatedly enter the chapter's present. The extra measure of rice, an argument between mother and daughter over a morsel left on a plate, the taste of rice burnt in the rain, counting the thread in the machine, and additional payment for extra sewing work do not construct

a uniformly golden past. Instead of a ready-made heroic portrait, Naira remains a daughter who wished to serve herself her own portion of rice, demanded proper payment for her mother's unpaid embroidery time, and disagreed with familiar household habits. Sarita's tears and laughter arise together; memory does not reduce grief to one colour.

Narrative frequency also deserves attention. The daily practice of serving rice condenses an action repeated over many days into one scene; all those days return within the single occurrence of today's altered measure. Sarita and Chandrika have different memories of Naira around food. In Kabir's household, Naira had another disagreement about rice and lentils. These differing recollections prevent the dead person's life from becoming the property of one source. There is no single official description of "what Naira was like": within different relationships she possessed different kitchens, ways of speaking, and habits.

Focalisation: Remaining Near Sarita's Mind While Making Room for Others

The narrator remains in the third person, but the selection of domestic objects is directed by Sarita's experience. Chandrika's compassion takes the form not of an emotional declaration made over an empty bowl but of putting damp firewood aside. Kabir, on seeing the third portion on the plate, does not immediately make a speech about someone else's grief; he first suggests a way of storing the food safely. Madhu brings news of the drainage, but asks when Sarita wishes to read the paper. A little girl asks for an answer to Naira's promise to show her some schoolwork, but Sarita does not immediately appoint herself Naira's substitute. These four visitors enter the kitchen with different social demands upon time. Even within a woman's mourning, the novel depicts the continuing reality of society.

At this point Sarita herself determines the scale of assistance she wants: instead of buying a new object, she asks for a small clean container. This decision marks a subtle stage of character development. At the beginning she appears to have little control over the hand governed by the habit of serving a plate; towards the end, in setting food aside, sharing it, telling a customer a date, and deciding not to read an official notice today, she reasserts small rights of decision. Yet this is no dramatic transformation in which she has "recovered from grief." The final passage leaves open whether the third measure will be taken again tomorrow. The character's movement is not towards complete solution but towards the autonomy to defer a decision.

The Chain of Objects: The Third Plate, Red Thread, Papers, and a Phone

The third plate of rice is a recurring object. It is not merely a symbol arranged as a fanciful memorial offering: the plate contains real food, insects move over it, and a decision must be made about which part can be used and which is contaminated. The scene is difficult because the emotion of releasing a daughter and the necessity of protecting food collide. The text makes clear that saving rice and letting go of a daughter are not the same thing. Here the object-metaphor reveals its own limit: a literary sign does not entirely take possession of practical living.

The small metal box containing Naira's private papers remains unopened. A red thread is freed from the sewing machine's wheel and set to one side, without being deliberately elevated to the status of an invaluable "final token." In a telephone message Kabir sends news of the medicine, but Naira's former "Mother, have you eaten?" no longer arrives. These three objects give different narrative forms to the dead person's absence: in one, the suspension of access to something private; in another, the continuity of work; in the third, a sharp sense of linguistic absence. Through this fine arrangement the novel carries the effects of a large disaster into the smell, heat, sound, and handling of things in the home.

Narrative Time, Variations in Pace, and Critical Limitations

The chapter's main temporal span runs from morning to night on a single day; numerous moments from Naira's childhood and more recent life interrupt it as analepses. Rain, smoke, rice becoming cold, the timing of a phone call, the customer's promised date, and the hour for medicine prevent time from remaining an invisible abstraction. Two scenes in particular—the exchange between Sarita and Kabir about the plate and the use of the remaining rice at evening—slow the narration. Wherever routine food preparation undergoes a small change, psychological duration expands.

In the preceding Chapter 125, Kunti's confession shook an enormous dynastic history; here the heap of rice and the condition of an empty plate change. The scale of events in the two chapters differs, but a thematic echo —the need to hear the voices of survivors and not monopolise the life of the dead—is produced on separate levels. One possible limitation is that the visitors in this chapter often speak with exceptional sensitivity. Chandrika, Kabir, Madhu, and the customer all recognise the limits of their involvement. There is comparatively little extended depiction of helpless, awkward, or unthinking cruelty in the presence of mourning. Nevertheless, Sarita's unresolved decision about reducing the measure, the practical problem of the third plate, and her memories of Naira's

stubbornness give these carefully considered dialogues the roughness of living experience. The final empty cooking pot does not signify a finally empty life; tomorrow's undecided measure is a possibility for the story to move again.

Chapter 127 — The Guilt of Survival

The Injured Doctor at the Beginning: Survival and the Difficulty of Telling One's Own Story

“The Guilt of Survival” begins with Aniruddha's bandage, a button on his kurta, and the impaired movement of his injured arm. A character who earlier treated patients now watches the appointed time for his own examination. This change of role alters the perspective of the story: the specialist's body becomes a place of pain. The enormous outward disaster is not narrated once again in full; its lingering effect becomes visible through the small task of fastening a button. The past is present through the activity of a wounded body, rather than through a lengthy retelling of the catastrophe. The “guilt” of the title is not yet a settled moral verdict but a name for a question circling in the survivor's mind.

Kabir's arrival turns the reader's expectations. Aniruddha fears that harsh questions will immediately be raised about Naira's death, the collapsed wing, and his earlier decisions. Kabir, however, first asks about the vehicle, the bandage, and the pain of descending the stairs. Throughout this unexpected exchange, internal focalisation rests with Aniruddha: the narrator recounts his fear and then shows the other character's actual conduct departing from his prediction. The gap creates tension without resolving it through a scene of forgiveness. Kabir makes clear that assistance with treatment is not a promise to erase the account of earlier mistakes. The relationship between them does not follow a simple line from antagonism to reconciliation.

A Double Autobiography: The Recurrence of “If I Had …”

On the veranda, Aniruddha's sentence remains incomplete: if he had not moved towards Jamuna's bed, his hand would not have been injured. Memories return of defects in the first supply report and of having seen water seep through the old wing. Inside Kabir a parallel grammatical sequence arises: he could have urged Naira to come home that night. The repeated “if” constitutes the principal rhythm of the chapter's psychological time. Actual past acts cannot be changed, but the characters compose accounts of several possible pasts in their minds. The author does not present these counterfactual accounts as actual events. Aniruddha and

Kabir both become narrators within their own minds, yet their imagined versions do not displace the final truth.

Kabir does not regard Aniruddha's injury as some symbolic answer that could bring Naira back from death. Shailaja's arrival adds a third independent voice to this subtle relationship. She does not permit the question of Saraswati Devi's death to be transformed into the doctor's private tale of self-punishment. Devi Gond's brief presence introduces a fourth focal centre: people demand that the surviving trainee provide a complete account of the dead Urmila's last moments, although the limits of Devi's experience are different. These voices prevent the generalisation that "all survivors experience the same kind of guilt." Aniruddha's injury, Kabir's mourning, Shailaja's hunger for answers, and Devi's exhaustion at having survived belong to four different psychological times.

Arrangement of Scenes: Car, Waiting Room, Prescription, and Home

The chapter's spatial sequence is Aniruddha's home → vehicle desk → car → new treatment room → medicine-distribution window → home → Kabir's home → kitchen on the following morning. Along the journey the red cordon around the old hospital wing, damp plaster, Phulo's house, and a blocked drain recall the continuing dangers of the outer world. Yet the shifting focalisation prevents the narrative from remaining fixed on scenes of destruction. It includes small acts of companionship, such as travelling alongside an ordinary patient, handling an elderly person's walking stick, and keeping a child's prescription safe. Everyday time after death thus returns to the story.

Aniruddha's experience of becoming a patient in the new treatment room is an important reversal. When a nurse calls his name, Kabir does not go inside without permission. Aniruddha himself says that he wishes to enter alone. Later Aniruddha personally reads his medical prescription aloud to Kabir. In these small scenes, the plot moves beyond the sweeping emotional connotations of "support" and instead shows its practical sequence. The character seeks to recover the right to make decisions about his own body. The coexistence of Aniruddha's earlier professional identity and his present dependence lends the narrative emotional depth.

A Separate Stream of Papers and the Return of Domestic Utensils

Many documents appear in the chapter: Aniruddha's wound prescription, a list of available medicines, the amended treatment report for Saraswati Devi, the building inspection, and the account of the accident. Their narrative relation is not that papers themselves pronounce a verdict, but that incomplete stories belonging to different periods and subjects have gathered on one table. Aniruddha corrects the wording "safe route" to

"the temporary route approved at that time." This change of words has narrative significance: a narrator of one sentence acknowledges the limits of an order that he himself had earlier constructed. The author does not stage this as the climax of some great revelation; self-revision is shown through the ordinary task of writing a separate note.

The rice scene of Chapter 126 returns several times in memory. Kabir does not tell Aniruddha the entire scene of Sarita's third plate; one character's private memory does not become a wholly public narrative for another. The cost of Chandrika's khichdi is asked about separately, Shailaja's private sorrow remains distinct, and the preparation of porridge for Subhadra supplies the following morning's closing scene. Through these recurrences the novel translates the epic scale of the disaster into minute domestic time. The injured arm of the opening and the heat of the cooking fire at the end form two different axes of action: the first displays a body's incapacity; the second, its limited capacity to choose work once more.

Readerly Experience, Unresolved Guilt, and Creative Limitations

The attraction of the chapter lies not in naming the guilty party, but in seeing different sequences of self-blame, accountability, and treatment-time within the experience of a "person who survived." It offers no concluding verdict of an investigation: the accident report, Saraswati Devi's death, the physical failure of the building, and grief for Naira remain connected to later parts of the story. Champa's momentary presence in the waiting room is a deliberate foreshadowing of the next chapter. The narrator specifies that Kabir knows nothing about her, so this event advances the reader's information rather than Kabir's experience. The transition to Chapter 128 thereby arises naturally.

An artistic limitation may be observed in the fact that most decisive statements exchanged among Kabir, Shailaja, Devi, and Aniruddha are carefully reasoned and logically organised. Experiences of grave loss could also have allowed more fragile, contradictory, or disjointed speech. Nevertheless, the pain of fastening a button, the silt on the road, waiting for an ordinary vehicle, the quantity of porridge, and the unfinished "if" offer the reader relief from this potentially didactic tendency. The chapter does not provide "a solution to guilt"; instead, it constructs a cautious perspective on the excesses involved in telling stories about guilt.

Chapter 128 — Champa's Treatment

Behind the Curtain: The Right to Choose When to Tell a Story

The chapter's first scene begins with a motionless drop, pain rising when a wrist is turned, and the decision not to call a name from beyond the

curtain. These three indications establish the relationship among Champa's body, fear, and social visibility. The personal story of the character entering the treatment room is still untold. The reader can see her bodily discomfort but not the entire account of the event. The narrator remains in the third person yet gives comparatively more access to Champa's sensations and hesitation. What matters particularly is that the narrator does not disclose the whole scene at the outset by exercising omniscient authority. The reader hears it gradually, in the measure that Champa herself chooses to speak. This deliberate distribution of information becomes the chapter's fundamental narrative principle.

Salma Sheikh changes the chair, asks whether privacy would be preferred, seeks renewed permission before removing a bangle, and allows pauses during Champa's account. Champa extends her hand for help, then pulls it back. This single bodily action concentrates the inner conflict of the narrative: a need for assistance and a fear of losing control coexist. She relates limited portions of the previous evening's dispute, being held back by force, a shove, and striking a wall; it remains undetermined which individual is connected to the full incident. She chooses not to tell the entire story immediately. In this way, under the title "Treatment," telling a story becomes a staged activity rather than a final disclosure.

The Return of Memory: From Public Humiliation to Private Fear

Descriptions of Champa's interrupted sleep, her startlement at a creaking door, and the fear awakened by a moving curtain link present bodily experience to the psychological time of the night. At an earlier municipal meeting, an excerpt cut from one of her private messages had been read aloud. She remembers the sound of laughter, but does not know who leaked the original copy. The causal relation between this analepsis and the present treatment room is broader than the physical incident that produced the injury: after the unauthorised public circulation of private words, there is fear that control over one's next account will also be taken away. The writer develops this psychological progression in detail but does not reproduce the entire private message. Instead of making the reader a spectator to Champa's humiliation, the narrative makes its aftermath perceptible.

The chapter's main temporal span extends from a day's consultation to night. Inside the room, questions, medical examination, reading a prescription, and waiting are developed as extended scenes. Once she goes outside, time moves more briskly: food beneath a peepal tree, the shelter doorway, a conversation at home, a small meeting, a new visitor in the evening, and a message at night. Yet memories interrupt this forward-moving sequence: the previous municipal assembly, yesterday's dispute at home, the mother's old wish for jalebi at the market, and the cut message

on the telephone. Champa's present is therefore not linear; it is formed among several pasts and a number of possible mornings.

The Relocation of Voices: Champa, Salma, Ruhani, and the Mother

Salma's language is marked by medical procedure and care in offering options; Ruhani is concerned with the shelter vehicle, food, and the register; Rukhsana's voice takes form through the taste of food and the accounting of wages; Champa's mother speaks in a domestic idiom of worry and entitlement. The encounter among these perspectives prevents "woman" from becoming a single kind of experience in the chapter. Ruhani waits on the outer veranda without asking to see Champa's detailed treatment report. Yet Champa herself raises the risk that the entry "women's treatment" in Ruhani's register could disclose identity indirectly. Ruhani's assistance is therefore not treated as automatically flawless moral virtue: she considers the objection and closes the register. Character development occurs here after an actual challenge.

The conversation with her mother creates a domestic tension different from the relatively ordered dialogue in the treatment room. The mother says that because Champa is her daughter she is entitled to complete information; Champa asserts her right to choose when she will relate the story of her pain. There is conflict here between closeness and boundaries. Both sides are afraid, but the experience of fear is not identical. The chapter neither constructs the mother as a cruel antagonist nor treats Champa as culpable for "withholding the truth." They laugh together again over jalebi at night, but a partial moment of laughter neither cures the injury nor automatically erases the earlier disagreement. These subtle opposing emotions sustain the complexity of their characters.

The Objects of Treatment: From Bangles to Envelopes

At the beginning there are two stuck bangles, a changed chair, a drop on a glass, and a medical prescription; at the end there is an iron trunk, a private treatment letter, and a separate envelope for possible testimony. Removing the bangles is a tangible encounter with the body's boundaries; the drop on the glass suggests a failed attempt at touch; the separation of envelopes provides places for two different stories of a single life. The distinction between the headings "my treatment" and "what I saw" extends the scope of the chapter's title. The document of treatment does not acquire the whole right to tell the story; the possibility of later testimony remains separate. The chapter thus ends not in a closed conclusion but in two distinct futures: an appointed medical review and an as-yet undetermined time for a statement.

The meal scene also creates an object-recurrence from Chapter 126. Champa's injured hand cannot hold a spoon, so she makes a morsel with her left hand. Instead of staring at the injury, Ruhani opens a bottle of water. The understated narration avoids an overwrought scene of assistance. Rukhsana asks about salt but does not demand the details of the injury; she takes down the heavy cooking pot herself while insisting that her wages be entered in the account. Through this recurrence of food, labour, and dialogue, compassion in Stri Parva remains continuously connected to the actions of real life.

The Visitor, the Poster, and the Public Circulation of a Story

A person arriving at the shelter gate carries a photocopy of a rent dispute. This visitor asks for information about Champa's room, but neither the visitor's identity nor any possible connection to the previous evening's shoving incident has been established. The reader may anticipate a familiar mystery-plot turn, in which the new visitor and the person responsible for the earlier violence prove to be one and the same. The original narrative, however, refuses this hasty connection: Champa distinguishes what she witnessed from a relationship she merely suspects. In narrative terms, the delay is not just a device for prolonging a crime mystery. It allows the central character to retain control over her experience.

A poster at the municipal building and the minutes of a meeting show two forms by which a personal story can be turned into a public statement. Champa questions the need to include an image of her injury in a public tally. The phrase “should be deferred” in the minutes leaves open the possibility of later display, whereas the revised sentence constitutes a more definite prohibition. This minute textual difference has narrative importance: the institution's collective voice is not fixed within the story, but changes after the character challenges it. Nevertheless, the writer's repeated resort to self-conscious and corrected wording also risks becoming didactic. Several scenes move closer to a prepared policy dispute than to the spontaneity of everyday conduct.

Dialogue-Rhythm, Incomplete Time, and Artistic Achievement and Limitation

Dialogue predominates in the experience of the chapter from scene to scene: Champa's consultation with Salma, Ruhani's vehicle register, her mother's concern, the shelter meeting, the request of a woman drying clothes, and a short night-time telephone message. Yet these conversations do not all serve one purpose. Some convey medical information; others exert social pressure, provide private reassurance, or establish limits upon telling the story. The real test of polyphony here is not the number of

voices, but Champa's differing capacities to decide within different relationships. She chooses privacy at the hospital, gives a partial answer to her mother, asks Ruhani for a vehicle, speaks of her safety on the phone, but sets the time of a meeting herself. Through this sequence, the character's agency becomes a matter of events and actions rather than a written declaration.

The chapter's limitation lies in the exemplary conduct of the medical worker and the speed with which several characters correct themselves. Salma takes precautions before almost every question; Ruhani closes the register as soon as she hears the argument; the secretary amends the wording. The social world after violence could also be populated by people who dissent, are careless, or fail to listen. The writer gestures towards some of that wider difficulty in the visitor at the gate and the hurried demand made by the woman drying clothes, but institutional resistance is relatively easily put right. This artistic imbalance deserves criticism. Yet the pain in Champa's wrist on the final night, the separate envelope, the unscheduled testimony, and a route threatened by approaching rain prevent any declaration of final victory. “Treatment first, then testimony in her own time” briefly captures the chapter's narrative arc. It means not the completion of a legal process but the restoration of the central character's authority over the time of telling her story.

Stri Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 125–128

Four Narrative Locations, Four Forms of Time in Grief

The locations of Chapters 125–128 are, in order, the ancient ghat on the Ganges, Sarita's modern kitchen, Aniruddha's home–hospital–Kabir's home, and Champa's women's consultation room and shelter. Through these changes of place, the narrative does not merely contract from immense epic loss into domestic routines and personal treatment. Rather, it opens different levels of social experience. Kunti's confession brings a concealed event of the past into public history. Sarita's third measure of rice gives rhythm to the everyday absence of a dead person. Kabir and Aniruddha's repeated “if” replays alternatives that never came to pass. Champa's consultation redefines the right to choose when her story will be told in the future. What the four chapters share is not simply the word “sorrow,” but differing practical circumstances in which stories can be told or withheld.

Recurrences of Time, Voice, and Objects

There are four temporal arrangements: in the ancient period, analepses of birth and a meeting before the war; in the modern kitchen, recurring childhood memories within a single day; in the wounded doctor's mind, a counterfactual past; and in Champa's private experience, an uncertain future. The third-person narrator's tonal register is comparatively balanced, but the consciousness at the centre changes continually. Kunti, Sarita, Aniruddha, and Champa provide distinct centres for the expansion of inward experience; Karna's foster family, Chandrika, Shailaja, Devi, Ruhani, and the mother challenge their limits. These divergent voices create the narration's social range.

The bronze lota, brass measuring bowl, Aniruddha's bandage, Champa's bangles, and her envelopes all acquire meaning through bodily acts. Recurrences of water, food, medical treatment, and papers connect the chapters without allowing their symbols to consume the characters' direct experiences. River water serves as a medium for ritual offerings; water in cooking rice is an everyday kitchen necessity; water used to inspect a wound belongs to treatment; a single drop on a glass in the women's consultation room signals unwanted pain. Preserving these different uses is a distinctive achievement of the novel's object-centred narration.

An Impartial Critical Judgment

The shared success of these four chapters is that the narrative does not create a single universal "rule of grief." Kunti receives no immediate forgiveness; Sarita does not settle the measure of rice for the next day; Aniruddha does not consider every failure erased by his injury; Champa receives treatment while leaving the date of her testimony blank. In this sequence, indecision is not a halt in narrative movement but an active condition of a character's existence and narrative future.

Nevertheless, an evident critical risk has accumulated across this parva: many characters speak with an extraordinary command of the language of their responsibilities, rights, and limits. The density of obligatory self-explanation can sometimes suppress the uncertainty of a scene or the sudden irregularity of speech. Objects, memories, and silences offer the reader opportunities to create meaning independently, but policy-like conversations sometimes predetermine those meanings. It would be appropriate to retain this tension as a criterion of analysis from Chapter 129 onward. This is not yet a conclusion about the whole of Stri Parva; it is only an interim assessment limited to the actual text of Chapters 125–128.

Chapter 129 — Ruhani's List

Beginning with a Torn Public List: The Reader's Entry into the Scene

"Ruhani's List" opens with a measuring bowl of rice slipping from Rukhsana's hand, a rain-soaked veranda, and a torn sheet of paper posted on the gate. These three objects disclose three distinct temporalities at once: the immediate time of preparing food, the protracted crisis of rain and a damp building, and the sudden social moment in which the shelter residents' names become public. The young man's paper bears the words "List of Shelter Beneficiaries"; how that list was prepared and who was authorised to read it, however, the narrative does not yet disclose. The narrator shows the wording first and reveals its institutional validity afterwards. Consequently, the reader enters like an onlooker standing at the shelter gate, possessing only partial information. The tearing of the paper as a nail is driven into it is not merely a theatrical symbol: this physical accident gives visible form to an instance of uncontrolled disclosure.

In the second passage, Ruhani's investigation reveals that the notice in the employee's possession had asked for "details to be made available for verification," not for names to be displayed. Because of this delayed disclosure, the "list" of the title is no longer a passive sheet of paper; it becomes a narrative of an order misconstrued, an old attendance register, and the mistaken transformation of that register into a public display. The room number beside Champa's name, the designation "ill" beside an elderly woman, and the names of the mothers of two children generate different risks of exposure. Champa does not suggest snatching down and destroying the paper; she asks how many people have already read it. This provides narrative continuity with the confidentiality of treatment in the preceding Chapter 128. The movement of a name from a private treatment room to the public gate turns individual fear into a social event.

The Several Purposes of a Single Name: A Register of Actions

The chapter's sequence of events unfolds in five stages. First, an old roll of names is posted at the gate, and Ruhani has it taken down. Second, Vinod Sah, an assistant municipal accountant, arrives with questions about the actual distribution of grain and complaints of duplicate relief; he proposes a register with three columns: name, room, and benefit. Third, Champa and Ruhani consider separate options for personal replies, the possibility of using another name, and a means of withdrawing consent; they reject the notion that a majority vote can authorise disclosure of private details. Fourth, Manjari, Champa's mother, Shabnam, Rukhsana, and Zubaida each choose a different degree of visibility. Fifth, amid verbal pressure to

suspend supplies, two distinct documents—an aggregate account and a restricted individual-verification sheet—are submitted to the municipal office. A new notice at the gate gives meal times and safe exits, not the names associated with private rooms.

There is no single "heroic victory" in this progression. Approval for the municipality's next consignment of grain has still not arrived at the end; Ruhani leaves blank lines for the copy, acknowledgement of receipt, and subsequent reply. Replacing the torn sheet at the beginning with a new notice at the end is therefore a practical change, not a complete solution to the supply problem. The grains of rice scattered at the opening are returned to the bowl at the close, a clear recurrence of an object framing the chapter's form. Refilling the bowl, however, cannot erase the earlier circulation of names improperly displayed at the gate. The narrator makes the limit explicit: no one knows for certain whether someone took a photograph that morning.

Multiple Centres of Focalisation and the Distinct Meanings of Women's Voices

The third-person narrator presents the setting of the action without establishing a single centre of decision. Ruhani's administrative vigilance, Rukhsana's actual work of producing meals, Zubaida's skill in making notices readable, Champa's fear arising from medical treatment, Manjari's occupational autonomy, and Shabnam's objection to a photograph of her child constitute distinct focal positions. The reader enters the chapter through Ruhani's name, but the woman named in the title is not automatically the final authority on every question. Champa, for example, identifies the defect in an original consent form that offers only "yes"; Zubaida exposes the irony that a list of people refusing consent could itself become a new public list; and Tara Binout distinguishes a safety notice about a hazardous wall from a resident's private account. Ruhani incorporates these interventions into her practice. Leadership here does not mean monopolising the right to information; it means being capable of changing an arrangement one has devised in response to others' objections.

Vinod, too, is rendered with some subtlety. His question—how many people actually live in the shelter?—arises from a genuine supply crisis, so he is not turned into a conventional villain. Yet his initial three-column solution joins person, room, and food within a single field of identification. Rukhsana's objection that "thirty plates" do not mean "thirty overnight residents" recalls a material distinction in the story-world, rather than a mere matter of document classification. The characters' verbal registers emerge from differences in work. Rukhsana

speaks of rice, plates, oil, and wages; Vinod of registers and supplies; Champa of questions and possible circulation of photographs; Manjari of customers and the price of sewing. Such dialogue strengthens the possibility of polyphony, although the characters frequently speak in remarkably explicit analytical sentences.

Narrative Time and the Spatial Drama of Rooms and Gate

The chapter progresses from dawn to night on a single day. The timing of food preparation, the official's arrival, the midday inspection, a further message in the afternoon, and replacement of the notice at night constitute the narrative's internal clocks. The past enters not as an extended flashback scene but through Champa's memory of an earlier private message, the shelter's old attendance register, and acknowledgements that arrive late. It would be incorrect to treat the "dual-temporal intertext" here as an autonomous epic timeline; the main action occupies one day in a modern shelter. Analepsis arises through personal recollection and earlier dates on documents.

The configuration of places is equally decisive: the gate, where anyone can read without control; the schoolroom table, where the wording on sheets is revised; a private room, where consent is heard separately; the municipal office, where aggregate figures are submitted; and the new public noticeboard, where directions to safe exits can be found. As the story changes location, the limits of focalisation change with it. Public and private are not merely opposed concepts: they become events through paths people take and places where papers are kept. Tara's examination of the danger posed by the damp wall, and the question of providing safe information, keep the earlier flood-disaster narrative active on this page as well.

Written Autonomy as Motif and the Chapter's Critical Limit

The blank space Champa leaves for "speaking publicly in the future," Manjari's chosen occupational description, and the notation beside Ruhani's name—"responsibility for reviewing the list again"—are three principal internal images. In the first, empty space represents the right to postpone a decision; in the second, self-selected identification becomes a means of livelihood; in the third, a name signifies not personal distinction but the work of further review. Their recurrence prepares the narrative ground for the major concerns of subsequent chapters: grief, survivors, and the public record of names. A small domestic scene with Champa's mother adds the dimensions of rest and a tired body to the policy dispute.

The composition also has its limits. The problem of correcting the notice is explained not once but by several characters in an almost sequential

manner; options, receipts, safe access, and limits of consent repeatedly threaten to make the scene into a complete policy workshop. Champa's aching wrist, the young man's nail, and Rukhsana's grains of rice interrupt this mechanical quality, but some voices remain uniformly well ordered. The author succeeds to the extent that, despite this risk, the narrative does not abandon the scene as lived experience, and the final decision on grain supplies remains open. Its achievement is not a "lesson about privacy"; it lies in the causal relationship through which changing a document changes the characters' conduct.

Chapter 130 — Draupadi's Remaining Days

Dawn After the War: Five Bowls and Five Absent Lives

The opening scene of "Draupadi's Remaining Days" begins with the sound of rice being washed in the royal kitchen. The time is after the end of the war, but the chapter does not begin with a celebration of victory or an account of a coronation. Malini has set aside five small bowls from which Draupadi's five sons once ate. The method of making death present through objects offers less a declaration of emotion than a direct image of absence. Although Draupadi sees the scratches on the five bowls, she cannot recall precisely whose fingernail made which mark. This uncertainty in memory matters: the narrator does not make the character's entire past available once more in the fixed order of a clock, but creates the present of mourning through incomplete recollection.

Draupadi asks that the bowls not be thrown away but washed and kept safely; she does not, however, wish to set out five empty plates every day while hungry people outside are made to wait. This single decision contains the chapter's central conflict: the preservation of memory versus the immediate needs of the living. Keeping memory alive does not require work to cease, just as continuing to work does not mean forgetting. The image has a profound intertextual resonance with Sarita's third plate in Chapter 126. Sarita's modern household and Draupadi's ancient royal residence are separate narrative locations; it would be inappropriate to treat them as a reincarnation of a single character or as exact equivalents of everyday events. In both places, however, an absent recipient changes the number of morsels, and daily labour becomes a way of measuring the time of grief.

Disorderly Returns of Memory and Bodily Time

In the fourth passage Draupadi repeats the names of her five sons silently. A grain of rice on Prativindhya's forehead, a question asked by Sutasoma, Shatanika's haste, and the overlapping voices of Shrutakarma and

Shrutasena return not in chronological order but as separate images of memory. The story's past enters the character's present consciousness as selected fragments. The narrator offers no facile statement that "everything is remembered" or "everything has been forgotten." In refusing to substitute the voice of one son for another's, Draupadi experiences the ethical privacy of mourning. Five is no longer merely a count; it signifies five separate lives.

The temporal design extends chiefly from dawn on one day to the preparation of the next meal. Scenes follow one another in the kitchen, assembly, courtyard of the wounded, Kunti's veranda, Gandhari's camp, Uttara's room, the encounter with Krishna, and a private cupboard. The pace is not uniform throughout. The scene of swallowing two morsels of hot rice extends over several moments, whereas the city's postwar arrangements are briefly reported elsewhere. Draupadi says she has no appetite but needs to eat two morsels. Later, in conversation with Krishna, this uneven bodily rhythm is voiced again: even when the mind understands the necessities of living, the body does not move at the same speed as that understanding. The chapter's particular narrative force lies in showing grief not as a progression towards being "cured," but through the body's slow resumption of its work.

The Expansion of Focalisation: From the Kitchen to the Victors' Assembly

The initial close perspective rests with Draupadi and Malini, but the narration gradually turns towards people omitted from the first calculation for the royal banquet: wounded soldiers, repairers of wooden chariots, carriers of grass, the families of women working in the kitchen, a patient with an injured tooth, and a girl unable to eat because she fears the night. These are co-actors in the postwar world. Draupadi asks Yudhishthira whether the people who cook the food are present in the assembly. The storehouse accounts include "regular provisions for the royal family," but omit the numbers belonging to the kitchen women's households. A real change occurs: after Draupadi's question, Vidura enters a new line in the proposal, and a recount of the stores is ordered. The outcome is not an immediate distribution of all provisions.

Bhima brings a wounded soldier into the assembly and demands food for him at once in his powerful voice. Draupadi intervenes to distinguish the bodily needs of two soldiers: one must be helped to eat, whereas the other needs soft food. This scene does not render Bhima cruel or irrelevant; rather, it gives his compassion a practical differentiation. Yudhishthira, the steward Prabodha, Vidura, Malini, and Draupadi occupy different speaking positions, but Draupadi's questions repeatedly change the direction of

what the others say. The female character is not merely a victim but a maker of the language in which decisions are taken.

Food for the Enemy's Side, the Right to Refuse, and the Draupadi–Gandhari Scene

In the middle of the chapter, the journey to Gandhari's camp marks a decisive social shift. Draupadi travels in a chariot without a victory standard and asks first for time to listen to the women with Gandhari. Here the place of the epic war's aftermath is not a public spectacle of triumph, but the self-respect of a defeated household. Gandhari and Draupadi speak of their dead sons, yet the narrator makes clear that their lives, injustices, and relationships cannot be measured by the same standard. The scene does not attempt to erase historical differences in the name of sympathy.

Charvi—a widow of a worker who fastened chariot axles, and herself a spinner—registers her objection before accepting grain from the Pandava royal stores. Draupadi listens to the civilian identity of her work and does not make acceptance of food an admission of victory. Charvi maintains her own decision not to eat, but food is not withheld from the child. The narrative outcome is unusually subtle: Draupadi does not "persuade everyone"; she preserves a place for refusal. Charvi's voice is an independent dissent, not merely an aid to the royal household's questions. The relationship emerging from grief is presented as conditional coexistence.

Kunti, Uttara, and Krishna: Three Different Rhythms of Relationship

Kunti's arrival provides a direct thread of recollection back to Chapter 125. Even after telling the truth about a birth, Kunti cannot change Draupadi's grief for her five sons. Between the two women stand no obligatory declaration of forgiveness, but a small piece of jujube fruit and silence. One character's truth does not replace another's pain: this distinction prevents the epic intertext from becoming a uniform ethical celebration. As the subject of meals and gifts at Radha's household arises again, Karna's story becomes connected with the living characters' will to survive.

In the conversation with Uttara, the refusal to treat the unborn child as a "replacement" for Abhimanyu opens a delicate form of futurity. Uttara shares half her milk and lightly laughs at Draupadi's decision to announce, without asking, that more is needed. The laughter does not signal complete recovery; it indicates the renewed ability to question within an intimate relationship. Krishna's visit, too, begins with a letter giving the wrong address for a soldier rather than a miraculous sermon. The crisis of mourning is met by the short observation that "hunger is not a festival,"

yet it remains tied to the practical timing of the hearth. The narrator does not make Krishna a solver of every problem.

A Cupboard of Five Objects, Recurring Rice, and Artistic Risk

In the latter part of the chapter a cupboard holds small objects belonging to the five sons: a half-worn die, a broken bowstring, a partly written character, the edge of a piece of cloth, and a copper ring. Draupadi does not forcibly assign every object to one particular son. This is an important artistic reversal: a visible object evokes memory, but an infallible attribution of names is not required. The five bowls at the beginning and a small bowl of rice at the end frame the entire intervening narrative. Amid the absence of her five dead sons, Draupadi asks for a limited portion of food for herself. Such a voluntary act must not be read as "the end of grief"; it is a small renewal of the everyday time of remaining alive.

Criticism must also register the chapter's limitations. In nearly every public exchange, Draupadi finds an ethically appropriate answer for the moment. The trauma following war could have allowed more occasions for a faltering voice, administrative mistakes, involuntary harsh words, and failed conversations. At places the discussion in the royal residence sounds excessively deliberate, like a modern policy debate. Nevertheless, the uncertain scratches on the five bowls, the bodily difficulty of swallowing two morsels, Charvi's refusal, the exchange of milk between Uttara and Draupadi, and the indistinct memories attached to the sons' objects save the narrative from becoming merely declarative. The "remaining days" of the title mean not simply the time after victory, but the difficult earning of each new morsel amid remembrance of the dead.

Chapter 131 — Sita's Fire

From Water in a Cracked Bowl to the Assembly of Fire: The Construction of Scenes

"Sita's Fire" opens after the war in Lanka's Ashoka grove, with a cracked earthen bowl. Sita uses it to water a new leaf on an ashoka tree: although damaged, the vessel has not entirely lost its usefulness. This ordinary act places the reader amid tangible objects, while the surrounding world holds the smoke of battle, burned roofs, and people awaiting news of their homes. Opening with water after announcing "fire" in the title delays narrative expectation: before the public trial stands a woman engaged in sustaining daily life. Although the military objective has been accomplished, there is no news of Trijata's friend's son, Madhavi's brother's name has been recorded in two different ways, and Dhanvati

must carry well water from a great distance. Such accompanying lines of action make the solitary spectacle of victory multivalent.

Hanuman tells Sita of Ravana's death and the safety of Rama and Lakshmana. Yet the narrator does not impose an immediate response of triumph upon Sita's face; her first question is whether Rama has been wounded. Receiving news and determining its emotional meaning become two separate actions. The questions of clothing, bathing, a palanquin, and ornaments arise in the same sequence. While respecting the labour of those who make ornaments, Sita chooses for herself what the public display of her body should mean. These scenes prepare the coming conflict in the assembly: will the woman's journey become an object in a victory procession, or will she remain a person capable of speaking? Her choices have been presented from the outset, so the public confrontation does not seem like a drama suddenly appended to the story.

Narrative Time and Layered Narration: A Clear Distinction Between Two Traditional Versions

The chapter chiefly encompasses one day after the war in ancient Lanka, extending into evening. The main locations follow the sequence: grove, road, assembly on the battlefield, secluded shelter, and return to the grove. Embedded memories open onto the river in Sita's forest life, Trijata's earlier experiences, the burned hut of an injured soldier, and the lives of unnamed attendants in the grove. In passage 22, however, the narrator departs explicitly from the immediate scene to offer a commentary on two narrative traditions: one ancient telling in which Sita emerges unharmed from the fire, and another widely circulating telling in which Sita has already been protected by fire and a shadow-form takes her place. The text itself states that these are not identical accounts of the same event.

This duality of versions is narratologically significant. On one level, the reader follows the fire kindled in the assembly at the present moment of the story; on another, the narrator recalls an alternative construction within the inherited narrative world. That second narrative level exists independently of the immediate present as perceived by the characters. In passage 23 the spectators' interpretations also diverge: some understand the event as a divine proclamation, others consider Sita's own words sufficient, while a soldier injured in the fires of war cannot bear the sight of the flame at all. The reader is not ordered to accept a single divine spectacle. Yet this plurality is not a "verbatim quotation" from an original Ramayana; it is a reconfiguration of different versions narrated within the novel. Criticism would be mistaken to collapse these levels into an assumption that the ancient texts were historically uniform.

The Assembly's Gaze, Sita's Speech, and the Direction of Questions

Rama's first public statement centres on the stain supposedly cast upon his lineage and possible doubts in public opinion. Sita answers by questioning the inequality between a forced abduction perpetrated by a criminal and the demand that the woman subjected to it submit to a test of character. The narrator attends not chiefly to the volume of speech, but to the direction in which the right to speak is exercised. Lakshmana's stunned question, the monkey physician's qualified observation based on what he has seen, Trijata's limited testimony, Hanuman's silence, and an unknown spectator's utterance of "fire" create distinct voices within the public scene. The action advances through tensions over who may address the assembly, whose words will be heard, and whose incomplete experience is being turned into a comprehensive judgment.

Sita asks Lakshmana how his private memory of knowing her differs from the assembly's conjectures. Trijata reports what she observed during the days she witnessed, without claiming omniscience concerning every moment outside her sight. The decisive feature is the limit of focalisation within the story-world. A character's lack of knowledge is not itself a fault, and the narrator does not forcibly abolish uncertainty. The critical method here asks what the narrator knows, which experiences are accessible to which character, and what kind of knowledge the assembly demands. There is no need to impose an external philosophical system of proof upon the scene.

The Many Meanings of Fire: Destruction, Display, and Involuntary Public Exposure

The word "fire" is first spoken by an unidentified voice. Sita does not silently accept it as an unavoidable punishment; she demands room to state her own decision and makes clear that people may demand a similar ordeal from another woman in the future. This foreshadowing takes the event beyond the familiar narrative motif of a "trial by fire" and makes visible the danger of its repetition in later society. Sita insists that no one is to seize her and take her to the fire. In harsh circumstances this act preserves a voice in decision-making; it does not signify endorsement of the system of suspicion. The chapter's verbal pattern—water, wounded hands, smoke, flame, vessels, and bowls—disrupts the singular meaning of fire as "purification."

The question of the bandage worn by the injured servant preparing the fire is a distinctive visual turn. Amid the royal family's accusations and replies, the small body of a worker enters the story once more. He builds the fire, but he too has a wound: beneath the public symbolism of the flames appears the actual body of the person who lights them. Later a soldier

remembers a burned hut at the smell of fire and sits with his back turned. These two scenes offer alternatives to a celebratory reading of the flames. Objects and sensations change their meanings according to the characters' memories.

The Narrative Continues After the Fire: An Incomplete Reunion

Sita is seen standing again before the assembly, but immediately stops the acclamation. The phrasing is crucial: "before the assembly" specifies the limit of a focal position; it does not prescribe a single interpretation of the miraculous for the reader. Rama explains the concern with public opinion behind his earlier statement; Sita says its effects will reach women far beyond this assembly. Their physical distance diminishes, but the narrative makes clear that the wound has not healed instantly. Reunion is therefore not presented as the "final solution to every conflict."

Behind the battlefield, the ordinary tasks of obtaining food and water return. Rope for Dhanvati's well, the search for Madhavi's brother, Trijata's having gone without food, the injured servant's bandage, and the question of whether the women in the Ashoka grove may choose freely to leave make a polycentric narrative of the postwar world. In the private encounter between Rama and Sita, the unsuccessful wish to recall the cool water of a forest river reveals how the ordinary language of a personal reunion has been suppressed by public argument about reputation. In passage 31, touching hands is a moment of meeting, not a verdict issued by a court. That distinction saves the emotional ending from a contrived posture of triumph.

The final scene returns to the cracked bowl. Dhanvati sees its usefulness; Sita gives it to her before departing. The water of the opening survives even after the fire. This recurrence creates a formal circle joining beginning and end, but the crack in the bowl has not healed of itself. The artistic decision makes the novel's purpose clear: one public episode cannot restore every determining right in a woman's life. She still requires her own future words, rest, and path forward.

Critical Counterargument: Modern Speech and Epic Characters

The chapter's principal achievement is to make Sita's speech central to the drama of the assembly while opening the possibility of independent presence for dependent attendants, water carriers, injured soldiers, and waiting families. Some conversations, however, are couched in exceptionally lucid and orderly sentences describing modern social problems. Almost every rebuttal by Sita is complete to the point of aphorism, while Rama's responses are sometimes comparatively restricted and hesitant; an imbalance develops in the acoustic character of their

exchange. More fractured, incomplete, and contradictory dialogue was possible. A further limitation is that the explicit account of two traditional versions momentarily interrupts the scene's dramatic movement. Yet that very pause prevents the reader from being confined within one cultural image called "fire." The essential success is neither a denial nor an affirmation of miracle, but the preservation of differences among versions so that the characters' voices remain alive.

Chapter 132 — After the Number

A Hospital in 2039: A Settled Death Count and Unsettled Lives

"After the Number" begins with an unsteady table in a temporary hospital office after the rains of 2039. A piece of brick has been wedged beneath one of its legs, and the table shakes when the red-bound register of deaths is opened. This small physical detail establishes the action's present foundation: the state's apparently stable tally is prepared inside a provisional, rain-soaked, unstable building. After the epic time of Chapters 130–131, narration returns to the modern period. Yet the image of food from those chapters recurs in Sarita's half-filled tiffin. Despite the vast temporal separation, the story establishes a fine thread of memory through objects.

The principal meeting completes a summary of the total number of verified deaths. But rather than declaring any number to be a symbolic "final truth," the novel distinguishes three matters: the count of confirmed deaths, the pending verification of individual identities, and the correction of associated records. A fixed number does not mean that grief has become still. The narrative's centre shifts from "how many died?" to "whose work, memory, and rights remain after that number?" Accordingly, the final chapter of Stri Parva opens the administrative plot of the coming Shanti Parva. There is no need to call this an invented new narrative framework: it is the original text's own transition.

Stages of Action: One Seal and the Waiting for Another

The chapter's sequence has six stages. First, Rama corrects the language of the death summary and deletes "all disputes concluded." Second, Urmila's sister raises not the question of her sister's death certificate again, but the separate story of payments due for washing and transport. Third, at Sarita and Kabir's insistence, the narrow heading "assistance to families of the deceased" is changed to "Register of Dues, Responsibilities, and Unfinished Work." Fourth, private letters, a trunk key, religious services, wages, treatment, and rehabilitation are placed in separate channels. Fifth, a higher office calls the register of dues a "local voluntary proposal"

without formal authority and raises the question of leadership. Sixth, the death count receives approval, while the second register receives only its first acknowledgement number and a notice of the next meeting.

"Final" acquires two different meanings in this progression. The verified count of deaths reaches an administrative conclusion, but payment, investigation of the structural accident, unfinished work on homes, and representation remain open. In passage 35, Rama stamps the first register, not the second. The image is formally effective because the same hand is shown moving towards two different kinds of conclusion. By letting two documents exist in parallel, the story holds together closure and the seed of a future plot.

Narrative Perspective: Sarita's Grief, Urmila's Sister's Voice, Rama, and Naira's Absence

The opening perspective rests on Rama's worktable, but the reader soon moves among Sarita's tiffin, Kabir's private letter relating to Naira, Urmila's sister's receipt, Devi's training slip, Ruhani's public food account, Neeraj's ritual register, and a key to Kishori's trunk. Within this polycentric arrangement, a dead person's life is not reduced to an official name. Urmila's sister makes it clear that she has received the death certificate: what she seeks concerns the story of her sister's labour. The narrator presents this voice separately rather than filtering it through Sarita's grief. Sarita herself pushes back the chair reserved for the chairperson, saying that being Naira's mother does not entitle her to make every decision. By this act she does not abandon her rights but creates space for other voices.

Naira's presence is paradoxically intense in this chapter. She does not appear as a living character on the scene, but is present through a file cover, an incomplete list, surviving personal letters, and questions left unanswered. Kabir declines to provide a private letter for public examination, although he agrees to separate the pages relating to public work. The question of publishing names from Chapter 129 returns: death does not automatically convert a person's privacy into public property. Sarita says that being the mother does not mean that every answer concerning her daughter must be held by her. The result is not an idealising elevation of memory, but a separate space for authorship and for the people entrusted with unfinished work.

Small Objects and the Narrative of Lives Left Untold

Objects in the chapter are not categorical signs but miniature and distinct narrative worlds. The half portion of rice in a tiffin is a remnant of Naira's missing mealtime at Sarita's home; Urmila's sister's damp laundry receipt

is a last remaining mark of working time; Kishori's iron key marks an unfulfilled private promise to a deceased older woman; Neeraj's brass plate and separate receipt tell distinct stories of labour and ritual; and the edge of Shashibhushan's half-finished cloth carries one household's memory. Through the continuity of these things, the novel expands the anonymous total in the death count into innumerable possibilities of independent human relationships.

The recurrence of such symbols also shapes the handling of time. Sarita seems to hear Naira's former laughter in the thin sound of water on the veranda. The narrator makes clear that this is an inward, memory-induced experience, not a supernatural statement audible to the public. This brief analepsis of consciousness is not a mechanical flashback: a present sound opens the time of an earlier affection. Thus the chapter's layered temporalities—the meeting in 2039, the night of the disaster, earlier labour, unfinished promises made at home, and future hearings—coexist within one temporary office.

Institutional Speech and the Characters' Dissent: A Story Beyond Closure

The naming of the new register in passages 9–10 is a turning point. Kabir wants a heading that will not allow one source of relief to subsume all other labour claims. Rama accepts the proposal but explains that the committee can undertake only preliminary verification, make recommendations, and follow up; payment will not materialise automatically. This limitation prevents the new register from becoming a magical solution. A recommendation to release an undisputed interim portion, between a worker's immediate need for food and the delayed examination of a contested bill, makes the scene more humane. A separate receipt for Neeraj's payment for religious services, and the decision of a family that wishes to use them, introduce another current into these polyphonic lives. There is no general declaration here for or against religious ritual, but stories of the different circumstances of particular characters.

From a critical standpoint, the announcement of Shanti Parva is unusually explicit at the chapter's end. An official letter makes leadership and authorised signatures a condition; a municipal representative offers to become chair; Sarita asks why other voices should fall silent in exchange for an official seal. The notice of the following day's meeting promises "public determination of leadership, representation, and authority to disburse payments." This is not a merely informational closing signal; it establishes the important persons, questions, and setting of the approaching conflict. "After the Number" therefore delineates a boundary

in narration: the dead have been counted, but the story of the social consequences of those counted lives is still unfinished.

Verbal Rhythm and the Final Critical Assessment

The chapter's strength lies in its arrangement of issues. The separate demands of Rama, Sarita, Kabir, Urmila's sister, Ruhani, Neeraj, Devi, Aniruddha, Gomati, Aditi, and the government representative converge in a single room. Yet the multitude sometimes makes the narrative expand like a register of line items. Departmental divisions, funding sources, serial numbers, jurisdiction, acknowledgements, and the next hearing recur so often that they can weaken dramatic tension. Reasoned public speech becomes predominant at the expense of deep inward pauses. The author counters this with half a portion of rice, a wet receipt, Kishori's key, Aniruddha's wounded hand, and Sarita's admission of what she does not know about her own daughter. At these points the text preserves its living depth.

The great achievement of the form is that the last seal constitutes a genuine ending, but not the end of entire lives. The fundamental opposition in Chapter 1 between the false announcement of Sarita's death and a kitchen that continues to function appears here in a transformed form, between real confirmation of deaths and a register of work still outstanding. But the comparison does not mean that "everything has returned to the same place": in the first chapter a person declared dead was alive, whereas Naira's and Urmila's deaths have been verified here. Similarity in the recurrence of objects does not erase the ethical difference between the events. Transforming its original thread, the narrative leaves an open ending for the struggle of the approaching Shanti Parva.

Stri Parva / Yuddha Kanda: Comprehensive Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 121–132

A Twelve-Chapter Design: From Reports of Death to Public Responsibility

The twelve-chapter narrative journey of Stri Parva (121–132) is not a straightforward sequence of funerary rites. "Confirmation of Names" and "The Last Body" begin with the painful scenes of verifying deaths and waiting over incomplete identification. "Gandhari's Question" and "Inside Mandodari" then open two distinct women's perspectives on epic mourning; "Kunti's Confession" changes relationships with the past by telling an old secret of birth again after the war. "The Measure of Rice," "The Guilt of Survival," and "Champa's Treatment" dwell on bodily time, guilt, and delayed speech among modern survivors. In the last four

chapters, Ruhani's list, Draupadi's remaining days, Sita's fire, and what follows the number successively open new temporalities of public visibility, feeding the living, women's autonomous speech, and social responsibility.

The alternation of the central story's modern time (after the disaster of 2039) and epic time is important to this design. But not every one of the twelve chapters necessarily contains autonomous scenes from multiple periods: Chapter 129 is centred on a modern shelter, Chapter 130 is a self-contained ancient scene in Draupadi's royal residence, Chapter 131 follows an extended ancient narrative in Sita's Lanka, and Chapter 132 returns to a modern hospital office. The reality of this distribution must take precedence over a general description of the narrative. Two different story times do not form a mere web of similar words; they reconfigure the questions asked by their characters.

Repetition, Duration, and the Echo of Objects

The main recurring objects include pages bearing names, plates of food, vessels of water, letters, pieces of cloth, and public or private doorways. In Chapters 121–122 a name becomes the painful question of identifying the dead; in Chapter 129 the publication of living people's names becomes an issue of fear and personal choice; in Chapter 132 a register of names for unfinished work opens even after the death count is settled. Meaning is not fixed: the same kind of object changes with narrative time, the characters' circumstances, and the context of reading.

The recurrence of food is particularly moving. Sarita's third plate (126), the different way Champa must eat because of her wounded wrist (128), Rukhsana's distinction between thirty plates and thirty overnight residents (129), Draupadi's five bowls and her two morsels (130), Sita and Trijata's ordinary rice (131), and Sarita's half-filled tiffin (132) are different forms of daily time after death. The beauty of this repetition is more than an extension of karuna rasa: the narrative distributes the practical continuation of life after catastrophe across unequal bodily, social, and mental temporalities.

Not the Sameness of Women Characters, but Their Separate Rights to Narrate

Gandhari's questions and Draupadi's grief are not the same political event; Kunti's guilt and Sarita's motherhood do not constitute the same kind of history. To gather Sita's speech before a public assembly and Champa's silence in a private treatment room into a single abstraction called "women's struggle" would be critically unjust. The storyteller gives different characters distinct ways to speak, defer a question, refuse, or ask for food. Ruhani's shelter offers a modern instance in the choice not to

publish personal names, while Draupadi protects Charvi's right to refuse food from the defeated side; Sita reverses the direction of questioning in the assembly; and Sarita refuses to make Urmila's sister speak through her. These are not identical events, but they share scenes organised to make autonomous speech possible.

Despite decentralised narration, the distribution of choices has limits: decisive women characters often speak in exceptionally clear, logically exact sentences. There was room for a wider range of disordered, laconic, and contradictory consciousness. Nevertheless, particular objects—the child's new sandals, the five bowls, a half-worn die, a cracked bowl, a piece of yellow cloth, a kitchen vessel, and an envelope containing a private letter—preserve the characters' inhabited worlds. Without these images, the chapters might have become simple social-information documents.

Narrative Processes Rather Than Substitutes for Historical, Philosophical, or Social Meaning

This criticism does not impose an external scheme of evidentiary reasoning upon its protagonists. The narrative significance of mistaken names, photographs, medical records, and death registers within the text is chiefly that they determine who learns which information and when, whose voice reaches the reader, which event becomes known after a delay, and whose decision changes the situation of the following scene. Nor are epic characters historical equivalents of modern characters: they belong to the narrative presence of another time. Where perspectives derived from Indian poetics—karuna, aucitya, and dhvani—prove useful, they illuminate images, silences, and contextual meanings; they do not turn the story into a declaration of theory without narrative action.

Final Judgment of the Collective Achievements and Limits

Stri Parva's great achievement is that it does not close the story at the climax of war immediately after the verification of deaths. Accepting a death, fashioning memory from objects belonging to the deceased, experiencing guilt at surviving, choosing the time for a public statement, recording the names of unfinished labour, and cooking the next day's meal all become events in the aftermath. Under the heading "Stri," grief is not merely private suffering but a force that transforms the narrative organisation of living.

Its most conspicuous limitation is the excessive orderliness of dialogue and the uninterrupted expansion of registers of responsibility. At times the story leaves the living scene and begins to collect policy points. One possible critical objection is that, even when effective, the modern language of rights spoken by epic women does not sufficiently preserve the

linguistic distance of their ancient narrative worlds. Yet the author repeatedly opposes this tendency through silence, failures of memory, bodily fatigue, incomplete receipts, and a refusal that remains intact.

The final meaning of Stri Parva is not "the adjudication of every question," but the commencement of social time after mourning. The seal affixed to one register in Chapter 132 and the blank spaces remaining in another provide an exceptionally concentrated closing image for the parva. The number of dead is settled, but the stories of the lives linked to them have not stopped. The next question of Shanti Parva—who will govern?—necessarily arises from this unresolved space.

Shanti Parva / Uttara Kanda

Chapter 133 — Who Will Govern?

A Chair with an Exposed Nail: A Material Prelude to the Question of Governance

The first scene of "Who Will Govern?" takes place on the veranda of a temporary office early in 2040. Seeing an exposed nail in the chair reserved for the presiding officer, Rama removes it from the circle and arranges the remaining chairs in a ring. This is not decorative detail. From the outset, the singular, relatively elevated position of the chairperson becomes an unsafe object, replaced by a more equal arrangement of seating. The reader does not yet know the outcome of the election, but the initial scene intimates a possible direction for the story. The red-bound register of verified deaths is closed; the register of dues and unfinished work lies under a sealed cloth. Even after the death count is settled, work connected with those lives remains shut away. From this disparity emerges the next phase of the narration following the closing chapter of Stri Parva.

Three different times are folded into this opening. The previous evening the chair was set aside for the chairperson; on the present morning it is found unsafe; the coming election will be affected by what happens to it. Sarita remembers how Naira used to remove her sandals before straightening the papers, but today that space is empty. Memory does not halt the present scene: through an empty place, the actual death in the preceding parva enters the present decision over governance. Grief does not itself confer a mandate to lead: Sarita refuses to demand an extra vote in the name of her deceased daughter. The "chair" thus joins three concerns—the wish for authority, practical risk, and the social place of an absent person.

The Course of the Election: Not a Seizure of Power but a Provisional Arrangement of Authority

The chapter's sequence of events is extended, but its stages are discernible. Urmila's sister first asks when the hearing over withheld wages will take place; Rama distinguishes the period of an old claim from the validity of new signatures. The municipal representative reads from an official letter requiring authorised signatures, but the allegation that the next instalment of relief will be blocked proves to be no more than something he has inferred from a telephone call. The meeting pauses when an elderly wheelchair user cannot enter; Tara's temporary board cannot be claimed as permanently safe access. Ambiguous wording on a notice is rewritten, and means of representation are considered without publishing shelter residents' confidential addresses.

After these obstacles, a proposal to defer the election competes with a demand for immediate hearings. Aditi proposes a working committee lasting thirty days, or until a broader assembly meets if that happens sooner. Rama separately records the roles of the coordinator, the employee receiving official correspondence, an independent technical team, and the office authorised to approve payments. Before voting, Sarita, Urmila's sister, Aniruddha, and Devi Gond each decline or rule out leadership for which they are unwilling or unsuited; Ruhani arranges restricted representation without disclosing private names. Ultimately Gomati is elected provisional coordinator by a majority, while the municipal representative maintains his dissent. Instead of all dues being paid immediately, work begins on forwarding the verified portion of Urmila's outstanding claim. This is an unmistakable change of circumstances, but the departmental seal, wage payments, secure permanent access, and the broader election remain unfinished.

Polyphony, the Cost of Time, and Focalisation

The third-person narrator does not remain wholly within one consciousness. Beginning with Rama's handling of objects and papers, the view expands through Sarita's memory of an empty place, Urmila's sister's dues, Uma's daily wages, Ruhani's confidentiality concerns, Tara's safe access, and the municipal representative's departmental anxieties. This is a polycentric scene, though not every character receives the same number of words. Rama occupies a mediating narrative position because she writes sentences on paper; the representative speaks in the language of the "department"; Uma asks why there is no "receipt for what has been sacrificed." Her question moves beyond social meaning to criticise the scene's own time: a three-hour meeting may cost a woman three actual

hours of wages. The narrator makes the time of public decision clash with the time of private life within the same clock.

Once the wheelchair user enters, the meeting resumes. This small interruption certainly slows the narrative, but it establishes within the scene who is able to participate in the election. The elderly woman's request that the notice be read aloud, Urmila's sister's declaration "I will interrupt," and Gomati's request to strike out "completed" and write "responsibility to arrange" serve different purposes in dialogue. The first concerns access to the story; the second, the legitimacy of interruption; the third, the result of revising language. A claim of "polyphony" is therefore supported not merely by counting speech marks, but by the practical difference made when someone's words cause the actual written sentence to change.

Recurring Objects: Registers, Boards, Food, and Empty Spaces

Two kinds of paper continually confront one another: open records of attendance, claimants, voters, and expenditure, and sealed envelopes containing private addresses, treatment details, or fears. Had the narrative stopped there, it might have become a story about administrative procedure. But the chair with its exposed nail, leaking tap, crumbling lime from the ceiling, Uma's bundle of washing, Aniruddha's bandaged hand, and rice in Sarita's container give ordinary life a material presence. At midday, out of old habit, Sarita first sets aside Naira's portion, then shares the rice with Gomati. This small action contains the difficult possibility of sharing time with a living companion without forgetting a dead daughter.

At the end the municipal representative, even while conceding defeat, records the date of the next meeting in a separate column for dissenting members. A political rival does not immediately turn from villain into ideal helper; his "fear about the work" remains. The presiding chair of the opening is not used at the close: Gomati sits on an ordinary chair in the circle. The artistic force of the recurrence is not that institutional office has been abolished, but that its visible grandeur has been reduced so that the complexity of responsibility can be seen more clearly. This chapter supplies the ground for questions in the coming Mahabharata discourse on rajadharma within Shanti Parva; it does not offer an identical outcome.

Critical Achievements and Limitations

The chapter's achievement is to show small, verified changes in a process instead of a victory defined solely by outcome: dissent is not deleted, the election is subject to a time limit, arrangements are made for a claimant to receive a copy of the forwarded papers, but dues are not thereby settled. The opening grief returns in the final daily meal, keeping the political scene

from becoming emotionally vacant. Nevertheless, bringing almost every issue—accessibility, representation, privacy, women's labour, medical autonomy, disputes among heirs, receipts for rituals, and the register of dues—into one meeting can seem an excessively purposeful arrangement. Many characters display an unusual ability to speak clearly, formulate principles, and reach conclusions. Compared with the confusions, irrelevant remarks, and circuitous disagreements of actual public meetings, a controlled narrative design predominates here. Even after acknowledging this limitation, the immediate consequence of Gomati's "victory"—a ledger entry for Urmila's sister—is a fine artistic choice: the story of leadership converts itself into a story of dues.

Chapter 134 — Yudhishthira's Reluctance

A Damp Stain Beneath the Crown: A New Experience of Governance in Epic Time

Chapter 134 is set entirely in the ancient narrative time of postwar Hastinapura. There is no independent scene of the modern committee here, nor grounds for calling modern Gomati a replica of Yudhishthira. Nevertheless, following the presiding chair of Chapter 133, the covered crown and the stain of water beneath it establish a clear connection through objects. In the preceding chapter the chair's exposed nail expressed the risk of assuming office; here a leaking roof comes into view before the crown itself. Royal power appears in a new form—not the radiance of an exalted symbol, but the questions of unseen repairs and labour sustaining the building that holds it. The first incongruity is that nobody seems available to answer why the roof leaks.

Outside the door stand a clerk with a worn pen, an old man who measures the grain store, and a woman carrying a bundle of thread. Yudhishthira wishes to renounce the throne, but the woman's question—who will pay the wages for the clothes made for soldiers, both living and dead?—brings his imagined withdrawal into conflict with other people's time. The inward struggle takes place not through an external sermon, but through the exact presence of a person and an object stopped at the door. Yudhishthira does not abandon his reluctance and instantly become an all-powerful king. Gradually he concedes this much: he cannot simply relinquish responsibility for the consequences of his departure.

The Sequence of Decisions: The Wish for the Forest and the Claimant's Slip

The action expands through the arrival of three groups. The first consists of the woman who makes clothing and supply workers whose payment

columns remain empty. The second includes a widow from the defeated side and a claimant whose oxen were seized; they question the designation "victor" used in the royal assembly. The third contains itinerant kitchen workers, water carriers, bridge-repair artisans, a boy from the stables, and people seeking temporary accommodation. Instead of reaching a dramatic peak through a single conflict, the author makes Yudhishthira's decision harder through the diversity of claims. This is more than an increased number of incidents: each arrival reveals the insufficiency of the easy solution proposed before it. Removing a tax on oxen does not answer the question of compensation for their value; the immediate gift of grain does not extinguish wages owed.

Vidura's questions provide a narrative turn: if Yudhishthira leaves the kingdom, who will make appointments, to whom may a decision be appealed, and who will hear the widow on the defeated side? Bhima responds with an immediate practical impulse; Draupadi's presence continues to make space for meaningful workers' voices amid grief. Yudhishthira undertakes some functions of government: opening relief grain, maintaining separate registers of claims, providing copies of slips, and leaving remaining dues open for consideration in the proper places. His final decision is not the explicit declaration "I shall become king"; it is "Today I will not withdraw from responsibility for the people's work." This deliberate indeterminacy sends the plot towards the questions posed beside Bhishma's bed of arrows in the next chapter.

Inward Focalisation: The Wish to Renounce and the Uncontrollable Memory of War

The third-person narration often draws close to Yudhishthira's mental experience: the crown seems to him like bloodied iron, a line drawn by a child in mud becomes an image of the state's temporary boundary, and a cloth moved by the air in the room sounds like arrows on the battlefield. At the end, however, the narrator distinguishes the sound of war-memory from its immediate physical cause: there is no bow in the room; wind is entering through a damaged window. This dual presentation preserves the truth of the character's traumatic experience without equating the time of external events with the time of inward perception. Such a brief, disturbing memory fractures the warrior's hardness without any need to turn the instant into a theatrical miracle.

Draupadi's perspective repeatedly breaks through Yudhishthira's self-centred inwardness. The deaths of her five sons are her private grief, but she will not use her sorrow as a reason to dismiss the woman's claim for the labour of making thread. Later she reclaims a right to solitude, returning to her sons' beds and closing the door. Through this recurrence, a woman

who speaks for society is not made into an inexhaustible instrument of perpetual public responsibility. Draupadi's grief and her political questions remain distinct even as they are connected. Her "silence" is unlike Yudhishthira's reluctance: asking for solitude places a limit upon her time, not a policy claim that work should be abandoned.

A Network of Images and the Dramatic Work of Dialogue

Water, bread, thread, pen, register, crown, and roof return throughout the chapter in relation to one another. At the opening Bhima's half-stale bread recalls postwar hunger; by midday, after drying further, it leads into the actual work of arranging food and water in a public line. The bundle of thread is a material sign of the woman's unpaid wages. At the close she ties thread around the worn pen, improving its grip. This is a striking reversal: the labour of the woman whose rights the state's record keepers have failed to write supplies the means by which the state's clerk can make his pen work. Here the story substitutes a brief act of craftsmanship for a long sermon.

Differences between sentences matter. Vidura's questions establish a succession of responsibilities; Bhima's impatience seeks quick results; the old man's measures of grain expose material scarcity; and the widow of the defeated side refuses to have her claim marked as charity. These distinct social and linguistic purposes make the dialogue-driven narrative dramatic. Yet the sequence of carefully structured questions and answers sometimes resembles a judicial inquiry and diminishes the spontaneity of living speech. Allowing almost every character to pose exactly the right difficult question reveals the author's overt control.

Temporal Construction, Outstanding Questions, and Literary Limits

The principal story proceeds from morning to night on one day. Duties owed before the war, memories of the dead sons, and uncertain future days of work enter intermittently. The scenes expanded in duration centre on submitting slips, the widow's oxen, the Yudhishthira–Vidura exchange, and Draupadi's objection. The decisive change at the end is that Yudhishthira does not go to the forest after evening. Such an ending does not announce the ultimate outcome of assuming the throne; it directs the reader towards the question of Bhishma's "knowledge."

The critical limitation of this ancient timeline is clear. The court of postwar Hastinapura frequently appears almost word for word like a modern public-service centre: receipts, appeals, copies, registers, limits of authority, and separate accounting heads for workers. This is not a complete objection to reimagining the original epic, but it may reduce the linguistic unfamiliarity of the historical period and the independent

complexity of its political structures. The narrative is at its best in moments outside this disciplined vocabulary: the damp stain beneath the crown, Yudhishthira's memory-induced sound of arrows that is not an actual bow, Draupadi's closed door, and the thread a woman ties around the pen. These objects connect the ancient story with questions of a new age without making their worlds fully identical.

Chapter 135 — Bhishma's Bed

A Bed of Arrows and Two Bowls: The Scene Before the Teaching

"Bhishma's Bed" begins with morning dew on Kurukshetra after the war. Wind striking the feathers of arrows, drops resting upon iron heads, two earthen bowls—one empty and the other containing water—and a child's question about relieving thirst fill the scene with bodily experience. Bhishma's name alone recalls the extensive and familiar tradition of his teachings, but the storyteller shows first not a learned discourse but a vessel of water beyond reach. The teacher's physical dependence and the listening child's ordinary curiosity bring the traditional elevation of authority onto human ground. This establishes the scene's visual structure: whose bodily need becomes visible before anyone's words are heard?

Yudhishthira approaches the bed carrying not his crown but two copies of the previous day's register of hearings. The claims opened in the preceding chapter are becoming the next events of the story. Through this close recurrence, the connection is more than formal; Yudhishthira's statement "I did not go to the forest" directly takes up the unresolved ending of the preceding chapter. Bhishma does not describe his knowledge as armour that exempts him from examining the harm done. The reader is consequently moved away from the expectation of infallible answers from an omniscient grandsire towards a scene in which a respondent with incomplete experience may himself be questioned.

Draupadi's Question: The Narrative Turn from Listener to Respondent

The decisive disruption comes from Draupadi's question. During her humiliation in the royal assembly, the learned men present continued their interpretations, yet the humiliation was not stopped. Recalling this, Draupadi asks what knowledge was doing that day. This is not an extensive analepsis: rather than presenting the scene of humiliation in full again, a sentence of recollection activates the reader's prior knowledge of the epic. The storyteller turns a famous event into a brief memory that motivates a present question beside the bed of arrows.

Bhishma admits his silence and inaction, but Draupadi does not become satisfied by that admission. She asks why his answer must now be heard, and how the harm of his previous silence will remain visible if he is once more elevated as an authority on knowledge. The dramatic achievement of this exchange is that Bhishma's confession does not become a reward that ends the scene. Draupadi is given room to test the reply again, dissent, and have her words entered first in the record. The author changes not simply the identity of the speaker but the order of question and answer: the grandsire's reply will be written after the woman's question. The sequence of listening is visibly transformed within the narrative's structure.

The Enlargement of the Scene Through Women at the Margins: Many Voices of Grief

Two other women have come near the bed of arrows. One has lost her husband; the other has not yet found her son's body. The reader's attention shifts from celebrated characters to the separate temporalities of these households. The first calls her husband a supply carrier rather than a soldier. She refuses to hand her claim slip to Bhima and asks for the clerk's acknowledgement instead. She is not merely an instrument for exhibiting pain: she decides through whose hands the next form of her story—the copy and receipt—will be made. The second woman shows her son's loom knife, but declines to declare him dead without having seen a body. Their incompleteness is not identical: the first woman's wage-claim procedure opens, while the second woman's son remains neither confirmed alive nor confirmed dead. Their conditions are not collapsed beneath a single heading of "widows' grief."

The chapter's sequence adds two separate slips for assistance and wages, the reading aloud of a public acknowledgement, the arrival of an elderly clerk from the defeated side, possible documents in an old cupboard, and preparations for a temporary place of hearing. Such smaller events prevent Bhishma's bed from remaining a stationary site of pronouncement and turn it into a public scene transformed by outsiders' arrival. At the opening, the path seemed almost closed by rows of arrows. Later, Krishna clears a way so that the wounded may receive treatment. As access changes, the reader experiences a new distribution of authority near the bed.

Focalisation, Duration, and the Writing of Silence

The narration is in the third person and centres upon a scene extending over one day around the bed. The viewpoint moves among Bhishma's pain, Yudhishthira's questions, Arjuna's glance at an old weapon, Draupadi's attention to a grass stalk, and objects in the widows' hands. Bhishma's bodily condition controls the speed of narrative duration. After a question his breathing grows heavy, water is delayed in reaching him, an attendant

wipes away sweat, and a request for rest intervenes. Such pauses interrupt the "flow of knowledge" and make the reader experience directly the limits of the elderly respondent's body.

Draupadi is initially silent, but her silence is not inactivity: while she looks at the stalk of grass, the narrator suspends the inward preparation for her question. The elderly clerk's silence is of another kind: he hesitates to name the previous authority responsible for an order while people publicly demand that its copy be opened. Bhishma's earlier silence is a third, distinct situation: his presence in the assembly and his failure to halt the injury. The storyteller gives three social functions to the same word, "silence": a time of intimate recollection, fear of giving an incomplete answer, and public inaction. The distinctions deepen the narrative life of Shanti Parva.

The Recurrence of Two Bowls and the Uncertain Outcome of Teaching

At the beginning two bowls raise the question of thirst. In the middle the bowl of water cannot be brought to Bhishma's lips, and Arjuna arranges for water to reach him. At the end Draupadi wishes to remove the empty bowl, but an attendant says it will be used for guests to wash their hands. Its meaning changes three times: from an inaccessible necessity to practical assistance, then to an implement of labour at the margin. This recurrence is denser than a general moral pronouncement, for in contrast with the weapons of the bed of arrows, the use of the bowl opens the daily organisation of living.

The final scene finds Yudhishthira asking that the record preserve not only Bhishma's teachings but separate places for Draupadi's objection, the worker's refusal, the unresolved fate of the missing son, and the elderly clerk's recollection. This is the authentic event of the chapter: not the completeness of a teaching, but a changed order of narration. Its effect resonates in the next modern Chapter 136 through the language of first statements and correction. The two scenes belong to different periods and must not be treated as a single historical chain of cause and effect. But the propriety of placing a marginalised woman's account first brings the two narrative times into creative dialogue.

Literary Achievements and the Necessary Counterargument

Bhishma's bed ceases to be a lofty seat of knowledge and becomes a place of grief with many speakers; Draupadi's former humiliation turns into a present question, and the working woman becomes an active participant through her receipt. The Mahabharata intertext achieves something important when the traditional source of answers himself becomes the

subject of questioning. Nevertheless, Bhishma's admissions are frequently modern, self-critical, and unusually orderly. Despite his exhausted body, almost every difficult reply remains balanced; the narrative could have allowed more time for broken memory, unanswered questions, and failed conversation. The repeated form of claims and receipts sometimes gives the scene a bureaucratic cast. Yet Draupadi's warning against turning an admission into "a new ornament of your greatness" prevents the glorification of confession. Bhishma's response remains one answer among many voices, not a final verdict.

Chapter 136 — The First Statement

The Right to Write the First Sentence: A Return to Modern Narrative Time

"The First Statement" returns to a community office at the beginning of winter in 2040. Dew gathers on the tin roof, Sarita has her brass container, and three separate sheets lie on the table: a blank statement form, the previous public summary, and a note of restricted consent. The shift from a Mahabharata scene back to modern narrative time is explicit; the chapter contains no independent mythological scene. The epic episodes of the preceding two chapters questioned who has the right to ask questions. Their creative echo here lies in Sarita's decision to write her opening sentence with her own hand. The characters of the two eras are not one person, but the question of who owns a story is posed anew.

The word "first" in the title is also significant. Sarita's first public objection came at the beginning of the story when she resisted the false announcement of her death; now she writes her first formal personal statement. Thus "first statement" means not the first instant of experience but a new stage in organised public narration. A fresh conflict develops between the meaning of the earlier summary and the status of the original sheets. Sarita says she has not come to prove repeatedly that she is alive; she has come to speak about her work and the errors in her decisions. This refusal keeps the narrator from fixing a woman's experience solely within the identity of a victim.

The Sequence of the Statement: Revising Narration as an Event in Itself

In the first stage Rama offers Sarita the option of reading the questions beforehand. Ruhani explains the rule that confidential names must be kept separately, and Sarita determines the limits between what she saw, what she heard, and what she inferred. Then the earlier journey of the original sheet of twenty-seven names, Naira's role, the completion of

reconciliation, the terms for publishing five private identities, and outstanding dues are reopened. Rather than an extended flashback, this is a dialogue-based condensation of incidents from many earlier chapters within one present meeting. The reader knows how long the list has been in circulation, but the meaning assigned to the reading of that old list is itself now in dispute.

Sarita admits a failure arising from the ambiguity of her earlier consent. The procedural summary was published, and the words "reconciliation completed" were correct, but readers could take them to mean that rights had been restored or payments settled. This admission does not declare the entire account false: it criticises an interpretative gap left between two true events. A young man's question outside shows how many different readings the public summary could produce. Rama does not immediately turn his remark into a formal allegation of wrongdoing; she preserves it as another example of how a text is understood. Narratologically, the reader of a document becomes an active character within the story-world: what that person understands changes the course of subsequent journeys and obstructions.

In the middle of the chapter Badri, his wife, and Malati question the heading "permanent arrangement" on a rehabilitation letter by referring to the actual water supply, school, livelihood, and claims over the old fields at the new settlement. Uma arrives between rounds of washing to obtain an acknowledgement for Urmila's outstanding wage slip, insisting on wording that does not equate receipt with payment. Sarita's statement resumes, and she revises "incorrect consent" at one point into "restricted consent to a published summary whose incomplete meaning was not made clear." In the end the three-page statement is signed, Sarita receives a copy, and the draft public correction is marked "not yet for publication." The first statement is complete, but the public correction has not been issued: that is the chapter's definite but limited outcome.

Focalisation: The Emptiness Within Sarita and the Others' Own Stories

The third-person narrator dwells upon Sarita's cold fingertips, her turning towards Naira's empty chair, a childhood memory recalled by droplets of dew, and the sensation of ink drying on paper. Yet Sarita does not become the spokesperson for every claimant. Badri's wife asks in her own voice about water at the new place and her son's school; Malati offers an independent account of the water rights of existing residents; Uma has taken time from her labour to come and insists upon larger lettering for the words of acknowledgement. In these scenes the story expands beyond Sarita's centred consciousness and then returns to her statement.

Kabir's role is interesting. He brings certified copies of Naira's unfinished public work, not the original private letters. Sarita offers him a place to sit outside; Kabir moves a chair backwards and chooses his own distance. This small scene creates the meaning of autonomy through bodily staging rather than ideological conversation. Later Sarita says that her inability to save Naira and the mistake in her consent to publication belong to two separate narrative sequences. The conversation between mother and son therefore reaches no comprehensive solution; it makes necessary room for distance within grief. The narrator repeatedly makes Naira's absence visible to the reader without manufacturing imaginary quotations in the dead woman's voice.

The Time of Memory, the Time of Writing, and the Open Story of the Next Day

The primary scene runs from morning to evening on a winter day. Within it, the original false death notice, the reconciliation of twenty-seven pages, Naira's work, the publication of a public summary, the Badri family's flight during the night of flooding, and old land papers come from different periods. These analepses are condensed through the characters' present questions, replies, slips, and remembered objects, rather than re-enacted as complete scenes. The chapter is also an experiment in "retelling an earlier story": the reader already knows the events, but their meaning changes through Sarita's revised account. The event does not happen again; its form of narration changes.

The time of memory differs from the fixed time of a document. Sarita may remember something new tomorrow; Rama says that the first statement will not then be erased but that a supplementary statement will be added on the following day. The narrator thus accepts the possibility that memory can change without treating an earlier sentence as necessarily false. The final temporal movement opens towards the future: tomorrow Aditi will open the original copy of an old measurement report. Sarita does not automatically declare it true or false on the strength of her own statement. This final exchange gives clear causal foreshadowing of Chapter 137, "The Old Report."

Paper, Dew, Food, and Water Pitchers: The Narrative Structure of Objects

The opening brass container and the third sheet do more than collect the past. Not opening the lid at once represents a delay before entering memory too deeply; laying a dry cloth beneath the container is a practical act of writing in the present. Sarita refuses to appropriate Naira's private questions for her statement as though she possessed a hereditary right to

them. She keeps her own work and mistakes under her own name. Meanwhile the smell of Rukhsana's rice, the hunger of Badri's son, Malati's borrowed water pitcher, and dripping dew connect the office scene to a world of human bodies and scarce water.

The difference between the chapter's documents is particularly meaningful. Once published, the words of a summary may remain in readers' memories; Sarita's draft correction is still unpublished. This narrative asymmetry keeps the event of "publication" separate from the event of "intending to correct." Badri's wife has it recorded that accepting temporary shelter does not constitute consent to a permanent home. This certainly resembles the structural problem of incomplete meaning in Sarita's account, but it arises in different life circumstances. The storyteller can distinguish thematic similarity here through the concrete objects belonging to a new claimant.

The Reader's Gaps and the Limits of the Composition

Chapter 136 has the particular achievement of refusing to make a person's self-criticism into an admission of guilt for an entire life. Sarita says the original count was not fabricated and that she does not wish to take responsibility for permissions that she never granted. In literary terms this is a subtle stage in the character's ethical development: her account is becoming clearer, yet this does not instantly alter events of death, payment, or rehabilitation. Changing narration opens the possibility of subsequent changes in social practice.

The principal artistic limitation lies in the concentration of too many carefully arranged issues within one meeting. Sarita's independent statement, the old sheet of twenty-seven names, private identities, Badri's land claim, Uma's wages, Aditi's measurements, Rukhsana's food, and Kabir's grief are all brought together with conspicuous clarity in a single room on one day. Much dialogue proceeds in the technical language of minute adjustments to statements; there is less room for long, apparently unrelated silences or moments when a character forgets. But Naira's empty chair, the chair Kabir moves back, Sarita's cold hands, and the corner of the child's bread balance the excessive orderliness. In the final passage Sarita takes her papers home while Aditi's new document remains open for tomorrow: not a methodological epilogue, but an unmistakable continuity of narrative action.

Shanti Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 133–136

Why the Postwar Story Becomes a New Beginning

At the end of Stri Parva the register of confirmed deaths had been closed, while the register of dues and unfinished work had to remain open. At the beginning of Shanti Parva Rama actually confronts the seal over that register and the chair that has been removed. This is not an accidental change of titles but the next phase of events emerging from what the preceding narrative left behind. A story once concerned with "who is alive, who is dead?" now asks "whose words will be heard, and who will answer for the work?" Governance does not, in this sense, replace private grief: Sarita's memory of Naira, the empty beds of Draupadi's sons, and a mother's unfinished search beside Bhishma's bed keep the time after death continually present in the narrative.

The chronology of the four chapters is a major formal achievement. Between the provisional modern committee of Chapter 133, on a morning in 2040, and the first statement of the winter in Chapter 136 stand two continuous postwar scenes in ancient Hastinapura and Kurukshetra in Chapters 134–135. The movement from modern to ancient and back to modern narrative is an intertextual arrangement; the four chapters do not take place on the same day or within a single historical period. In Chapter 134 Yudhishthira provisionally decides not to leave for the forest; in Chapter 135 he takes his questions to Bhishma; in Chapter 136 the modern Sarita corrects the words of her written statement herself. What connects this sequence is not the sameness of decisions but the successive transformation of the questions.

Distributing Vision and Voice in Place of Expectations of "Government" and "Knowledge"

In Chapter 133 Rama's arrangement of chairs in a circle, the delayed entry of the elderly wheelchair user, and Gomati's sitting on an ordinary chair all shift the centre of authority. In Chapter 134 the damp stain beneath the crown, the thread-carrying woman standing at the door, and Draupadi's closed door reveal a distance between public aspirations to govern and private suffering. In Chapter 135 the grandsire's bed of arrows becomes a place from which women ask questions. In Chapter 136 Sarita writes the first sentence of her statement herself. These four actions with objects—moving the chair, not putting on the crown, changing the order of teaching, and revising the words of a statement—form a continuous formal series.

Whereas a conventional epic perspective might remain centred on the words of the king and grandsire, Draupadi's objection, the defeated side's widow, the mother carrying a loom knife, modern Uma, and Badri's wife change the direction of attention here. But it would exaggerate matters to say that "all voices are equal." The narrator continues to make important mediators of those who write, including Rama, Vidura, and the epic author; ordinary claimants usually enter the record through them. Alongside the achievement of polyphony, criticism must attend to this inequality of mediation.

Narrative Time, Recurrence, and New Meaning

The four chapters are built around four restricted scene-times: Chapter 133 runs from dawn to evening on voting day; Chapter 134, from day into night in a royal room after the war; Chapter 135, from morning at Bhishma's bed to the return towards the city gate; and Chapter 136, from morning to evening on a modern winter day. Very long histories repeatedly enter these short durations: Naira's death, the old registers of names, humiliation in the Mahabharata assembly, refugees from war, the false declaration of Sarita's death, and unfinished decisions on rehabilitation. Most analepses are not complete reconstructions of the past, but brief memories activated by present conversation or objects.

Recurring groups of objects also gain changing meanings. In Chapter 133 the chair raises questions of leadership and physical access; in Chapter 136 the chair Kabir moves backwards becomes an assertion of the freedom to choose distance in conversation. Water in Chapter 133 is a leaking tap and the repair of access; in Chapter 134, a damp palace roof; in Chapter 135, Bhishma's thirst and a bowl for guests; in Chapter 136, a lack of taps in a new settlement and winter dew. Registers and acknowledgements are active across all four chapters, but their purposes change: an election's duration, wartime dues, the multiple voices heard beside the bed, and Sarita's developing self-account. Showing an object repeatedly is not in itself mere repetition. Meaning arises by asking who used it, when, and how the narrative circumstances changed afterwards.

Collective Achievements and Structural Limits

A major achievement of these four chapters is their narrative openness. Gomati is elected, but her responsibilities are not automatically discharged; Yudhishthira does not go to the forest, but no irrevocable, explicit declaration of kingship follows; Bhishma's answer is heard, but the history of his silence is not erased; Sarita signs her first statement, but its correction has not yet been published. In each case, a small decisive action remains separate from its prolonged and incomplete effects. Thus the postwar story does not become the account of a single moral victor.

At the same time, the administrative vocabulary of the reimagined ancient rajadharma and of the modern committee scenes becomes very similar and highly ordered. Payment registers, separate heads of claim, acknowledgements, limits of authority, the sequence of hearings, and the next date recur in ways that can diminish differences of region, period, and character voice. Sometimes the storyteller too quickly turns difficult social questions into orderly procedures for their solution. The tendency is especially visible in Chapters 133 and 136; in Chapters 134–135 it reduces the linguistic specificity of the ancient narrative period. But a damp stain on a roof, a piece of thread, a bowl beside the bed of arrows, and winter dew return the story to a tangible bodily world.

The conclusion of this opening Shanti Parva sequence is not that "justice has now been established." The more precise narratological judgment is that the author shifts the story away from the climaxes of death and victory and into the time of unfinished responsibility. At the end of Chapter 136 Aditi says that she will open her earlier measurements, providing a clear causal opening for Chapter 137, "The Old Report." This is an actual means by which the narrative progresses, not merely another declaration on a matter of policy.

Chapter 137 — The Old Report

Dust, a Brass Scale, and the Visual Return of a Past Decision

"The Old Report" begins not with a new accident or a political speech but with the small action of cleaning an old measuring scale. Aditi does not blow away the dust; she wipes the scale with the corner of a damp cloth, and its first marking has almost disappeared. This image gives the story's past a physical presence in the present. The report prepared with that scale lies on the office table; beside it Tara has placed Binout's site notebook and the municipality's receipt register. The narrator's initial signal is that all three documents describe different edges of the same tract of land: divergent accounts of the same place cannot simply be dissolved into a single event. The past appears here not through a fully staged flashback, but through the reuse of an object and the present consequences of a sentence written earlier.

After the final confirmation of death in Stri Parva and the first testimony in Shanti Parva, the narrative centre shifts in this chapter from Sarita to Aditi. Grief has not ended; the narrator wishes to show how social work proceeds in its aftermath. Referring to Sarita's first statement, Aditi says that she will not conceal an earlier decision by pasting fresh figures over it. This declaration links the scene to the preceding chapter, though the two decisions differ. Sarita publicly corrected the language in which she described her experience; Aditi withdraws the public use of a technical statement she had previously signed. The similarity between these acknowledgments does not render the characters' lives identical. It is a recurring narrative structure of accountability.

Sequence of Events: Not Erasing the Original Page, but Changing Its Use

The chapter's events are gradual and precise. Mamta shows the blank receipt field for her safety equipment; Aditi understands how an earlier phrase such as "suitable for external inspection" came to be read as an authorisation for safe work. Tara reports that the reference point for the old gradient cannot be found. Gomati then observes that withdrawing the old report will not, by itself, withdraw the departmental orders issued on its basis. The first six textual segments thus contain three distinct changes: recognition of a linguistic error, renewed visibility of a worker's previously recorded dissent, and preparation of a distribution list of the offices that must receive the correction. The narrator treats the events not merely as the writing of papers, but as the afterlife of decisions travelling through different periods of time.

In the middle section, Ratan's family-drawn map, Suraj's agricultural debt, the paths walked by women fetching water, Paro the stonecutter's tools, and Rani Halalkhor's separate register of contractual working hours arrive successively at the official table. These arrivals are not merely devices for extending a list of characters; each unsettles an unspoken assumption behind the earlier report. Showing an old river mouth on a map does not settle present ownership; the ability to handle a chisel is not knowledge of the safe load on a wet bank; and the receipt given to Mamta, a municipal employee, and the payment due to Rani, a contract worker, constitute two different experiences. Equivalences previously taken for granted now break apart and become conditions for the story's next decision.

The group then goes to inspect both sides of the Purandhar channel and the embankment. The voices of the warehouse clerk, Ratan, Tara, Phulo, and Suraj turn the stationary office scene into the changing spatial scene of the river. It remains undecided whether a damp trace at the old mouth was made by the present current, a former channel, or drainage from the warehouse. Phulo asks whose house the water will enter if the embankment is cut. Her question shifts the narrative focus from the raised embankment to the homes and thresholds below. Nothing is cut at the site. Precisely this action not taken has significance as an event, because an unsafe intervention is stopped.

At the close Aditi does not amend the original report in ink; she signs a separate letter of withdrawal. The original is preserved, departmental copies remain distinct, and the investigation team receives a sealed copy. A public correction is posted on the noticeboard; neither new measurements of the water nor a final conclusion about the cause of Naira's death is announced. On the last page Gomati opens four separate headings for questions. This directly prepares Chapter 138. The ending, therefore, is not the final resolution of a past error, but the construction of a new narrative framework for investigation.

Narrative Time: One Day from Dawn to Dusk and a Long Administrative Past

The external duration extends from dawn to darkness on a single day. Aditi's scale in the morning, the site inspection at Purandhar in the afternoon, and the noticeboard and departure of messengers in the evening provide three temporal markers and a firm sequence. Within that day, however, the narrative repeatedly recalls years of changed terrain, earlier permissions, Mamta's old objection, Ratan's inherited hand-drawn map, and the circumstances of Naira's death. Rather than construct an extensive flashback, the author makes the past part of the present by

rereading archival documents. Thus the story's duration remains one day even as its social consequences reach far backward.

The return of the same written sentence is particularly important as narrative repetition. Earlier, "ordinary repair is immediately possible" circulated as a comparatively confident directive; now its meaning is restricted to the outer, safe portion. This revised reading of a single sentence is the author's temporal device: changing an earlier decision does not erase its past, but alters the grounds of action in the present. Yet this rereading is sometimes carried out through excessively explicit explanatory dialogue. At such moments the reader might have been allowed greater freedom to discover meaning through the objects themselves.

Focalisation and the Distribution of Voices

The third-person narrator opens with Aditi's hands, the measuring scale, and her hesitation before signing, but the whole chapter is not a solitary journey through Aditi's consciousness. Mamta preserves the date of her previously written objection; Paro asks for wages for safe work rather than a risk allowance; Rani states her outstanding payment separately; and Phulo speaks from the condition of water standing outside lower-lying homes. The focal centre moves among these women's experiences. Polyphony here does not merely mean naming different occupations: the characters determine the limits of their own judgments and refrain from acting as spokespersons for one another.

Sarita's narrative presence is measured. She does not bring Naira's notebook, but comes to listen; she then asks whether the old report actually establishes the cause of Naira's death. Between her two interventions the author does not repeat the extended story of her grief. This restraint is an important means of transition from the organised mourning of Stri Parva to social life after grief in Shanti Parva. At dusk Sarita asks only that the next question retain a separate name. Her request becomes an image for the new method of naming in Chapter 138.

Recurring Images of Water, Place, Tools, and Blank Fields

The river is not a picturesque landscape here. The high embankment, the lower settlement, the warehouse wall, the field boundaries, and the footpaths of women collecting water alter the characters' speech and actions because they occupy different positions in space. When one of the women traces a bend with her finger on the ground, Tara marks it on a map but does not immediately declare the line of a new drain. The story here brings into conversation the path walked by a local body and the institution's map. The result is an initial correction of what can be seen, not a completed repair.

The image of the "blank field" appears first as the zero entered against Mamta's receipt of safety equipment; at the site Tara leaves an empty white box marked "source verification pending"; and at the end Gomati opens four new fields. The meaning of one visual form changes: first, assistance not received; second, uncertainty expressly acknowledged; third, a possible future branch of the plot. This recurrence is one of the chapter's concentrated achievements. Nevertheless, phrases such as "keep it separate," "a separate question," and "a separate investigation" recur explicitly in dialogue. A certain tension develops between the image's subtlety and the narrator's explanatory language.

Literary Achievement and Counterargument

The chapter's chief success lies in Aditi's development as a character. Her admission does not instantly make her innocent or heroic; she allows her earlier signature to become an object of scrutiny. Mamta prevents her previous dissent from being overwritten; Paro protects the conditions of her work; and Tara keeps open the difficulty of establishing the actual water conditions on either side. The plot binds retrospective responsibility to concrete action in the present. The decision not to tear up the original deepens the story's understanding of memory: the mark of what was wrong must survive so that the time during which it exerted influence remains visible.

One limitation is that several characters enter in much the same way: someone brings a file or tool, describes an experience, and Rama or Gomati records it separately. The repeated arrangement occasionally makes the pacing resemble a list. Even so, the site inspection, Paro's chisel, Phulo's single-line question, and the dust Aditi leaves unwiped lend the chapter distinctive visual density. It clearly establishes its final purpose: the public withdrawal of an error and a separate narrative route through its unresolved consequences.

Chapter 138 — Separate Categories of Responsibility

The Space Between Four Files: Division as Plot

Chapter 138 takes up the story precisely where Chapter 137 ended. Aditi's letter of withdrawal lies on the table, Rama has already rejected a proposal to cover it with new papers, and Gomati opens four empty files. Their titles —the physical sequence of events, possible dereliction of duty, allegations of unlawful gain, and allegations of deliberate violence—are not themselves investigative findings. The chapter proceeds through the struggle to maintain a proper distance between these names. Gomati initially leaves a space between the files; at the end she watches the shadow of one wall on water break into four sections. Between these images, the chapter asks whether visual separation clarifies the complexity of real lives or fragments them.

The narrator begins from the still centre of the table and its objects, but two extreme demands of political language immediately intrude: write “murder” first, or write “accident” and bring everything to an end. Gomati's response does not pronounce an immediate verdict; it slows the tempo of storytelling. This delay has social risks. Sarita and Kabir's grief, withheld workers' wages, and public fear all generate a demand for a name without delay. The author creates tension between the wish to name and the need to spend time understanding the event. The tension is strictly narratological, because the question is **who will tell the story, in what order, and how much of what remains unknown will be acknowledged**.

Register of Events: From Opening the Files to Dispatching Them

Kabir brings only the outer cover of Naira's notebook; he leaves her private writing at home. This scene establishes a physical boundary around mourning. Aditi brings the letter retracting her earlier conclusion. Tara objects to combining watermarks, a blocked drain, weakness in a wall, and public conjecture into a single visual line. A municipal letter attempts to place responsibility for unauthorised filling on labourers by citing the numbers in the earthworkers' wage register. One earthworker acknowledges carrying soil but refuses to assume responsibility for maps and instructions made by others. Through this sequence, the initial crisis changes from a general accusation to the question of **whose actions are being left outside the account**.

Material invoices, timesheets, receipt slips, and an unresolved difference between the river names “Varuna” and “Varune” appear in the middle section. An assistant wants to identify two places on the strength of their similar sound; Naira's earlier note, “source verification pending,” leaves

open the possibility that they are distinct sites. The episode reconnects the prolonged concern with names and registers to earlier parvas. On seeing Naira's handwriting, Kabir momentarily believes that he hears her voice, although the actual sound outside comes from the striking of a water vessel. The narrator distinguishes memory-induced perception from an external sound; the inward echo of mourning does not become a supernatural return. This brief scene effectively brings feeling into administrative prose.

Sarita subsequently insists that her dead daughter's private letter not be made public. The committee discusses the limits of its authority; the privacy of Ruhani's shelter and Champa's medical information is preserved; and the wages owed to Urmila's family are entered in a separate register of dues rather than one of the four accusatory files. The department again urges withholding wages; Gomati proposes a reply that records the labour representative's objection. In the final section, four distinct dispatch letters are prepared, each naming the office required to answer, a date, and the missing records. The files are open; responsibility has not been adjudicated. That is the chapter's limited but real outcome.

Narrative Time and the Pace of Events: One Day, Many Unfinished Times

The main scene lasts from dawn until the first lamp of night. Within it occur brief recollections of several earlier time streams: Aditi's former report, Gomati's eight loads of earth, Naira's old note on location, Urmila's unpaid wages, and Sarita's confirmation of death at the hospital. None of them, however, opens into a self-contained earlier scene. They become contexts that change the present dialogue. Most of the chapter's duration consists of the dramatic scene of office discussion; the brief mention of dispatching the files accelerates the sequence of events.

There is a significant temporal inequality between workers and officials. For an official, the period of inquiry is a set of administrative dates; for a worker, that same interval means interest accumulating on household debt, an unlit cooking hearth, and income withheld. The elderly woman demanding Urmila's wages does not ask for the investigation of death to stop; she asks that payment for work performed while alive should not be stopped. The narrator thus opposes the immediate time of family livelihood to the linear official time expressed as “payment after the inquiry is completed.” This divided temporality saves the chapter from becoming merely a legal dialogue.

Focalisation: From Number to Father, from File to Person

The third-person narrator guides the reader through the office actions of Gomati and Rama, yet the principal centre of perception continually moves. An earthworker's cracked palm, Kabir's confused experience of hearing, Sarita stopping on the path to open a water bottle, and the elderly woman folding her receipt into her sari make individual experience visible. The official letter treats the worker as a number; the narrator returns to that number its body, home, and capacity to decide. This does not mean that every worker's statement becomes a finding; the worker's acknowledgment of his own actions must also be preserved within the story.

Gomati's presentation of her own position is particularly subtle. She is both a witness to earth-moving labour and the committee's convenor; she seeks review by an independent member of the payment owed for her own eight loads. Her status as heroine is therefore not made into a single, complete moral virtue. The separation of her roles is shown as a practice within dialogue. Nor is the opposing assistant silenced. His question—when will all this end if so many files are opened?—sounds almost like a comment on the potential length of the story itself. Gomati answers him, but the question remains with the reader.

Naira's Absence and the Double Meanings of Objects

Kabir has only the cover of Naira's notebook, not its pages of writing; one of her brief older comments is in a file, but it cannot make a new decision in the present. The narrative force of the absent character lies not in a miraculous appearance but in a fresh reading of her earlier caution. Sarita refuses to let her daughter become an object through which four disputed causes are defined. She insists that the separate statement confirming death, personal belongings, and service-related dues be kept distinct. This is not a complete repetition of the maternal grief of Stri Parva, but a continuation of grief's altered position in social life.

At the level of imagery, the gaps between four files, copies of receipts, Kabir's empty notebook cover, and the image of a wall divided into four in water speak to one another. In the final reflection there is really only one wall; the four parts are created by its moving image. The metaphor makes visible the limits of register-based distinctions: separating files does not separate actual people, households, bodies, and social institutions. Kabir's closing question—must the cause be proved first, or should an already established due be paid first?—becomes a motive force for the events of the ensuing chapters.

Stylistic Achievement, the Risk of Repetition, and Outcome

The chapter's principal achievement is a many-layered narrative arrangement in which "responsibility" ceases to be a newspaper headline and becomes a complex process of acts, orders, interruptions, and experiences. The numbered worker's independent statement, a small domestic memory, Urmila's unpaid wages, Ruhani's privacy, and the department's haste are all brought to the same table, but no one's story annexes the fictional space belonging to another. Separating the four files also separates levels of narration.

Its possible weakness is the excessively orderly succession of incidents. Almost every character states the limits of their testimony with remarkable precision; such uniform linguistic restraint can diminish the unpredictability of actual grief, anger, and financial fear. In particular, the officials' extreme vocabulary set against Gomati and Rama's measured replies turns some scenes into predictable debates. Yet Kabir's brief auditory mistake, the receipt folded into the elderly woman's sari, and the final metaphor of reflected water break through this formality. No culprit has been identified; what had earlier been called "collective responsibility" now permits the story to distinguish the differing times and experiences of its many participants. That is the chapter's genuine narrative change.

Chapter 139 — The Return of Argument

Two Verandas in Two Times: The Chapter's Dual-Temporal Construction

“The Return of Argument” reopens an independent ancient time stream at this stage of Shanti Parva. At the outset lime dust falls from the wall of Udayana's study, a chest of palm-leaf manuscripts is moved, and two pages —Udayana's inference and a Mimamsaka visitor's objection—are in danger of sticking to the wet floor. The room is physically unsafe; the two written expressions of opposing positions might also tear. The ancient disputation thus opens amid fragile objects, not a celebration of victory. Before introducing formal disagreement, the narrator shows a crisis in the preservation of writing itself.

In textual segment 10, the scene suddenly opens on Rahina Thakurai's photocopying shop with the words “in a distant city, one morning in 2040.” Udayana's disputation is left midway; the modern story introduces withdrawn family customers and questions about payment for work and the consequences of testimony. The narrative returns to the ancient veranda in segment 15, to Rahina's shop in 19, to Udayana in 25, and to the modern committee room in the last two segments. This is **parallel editing across two periods**, not the retelling of one event. The characters inhabiting the timelines never meet, and the modern Rama does not know the outcome of the ancient philosophical debate. Their relationship is established at the level of meaning: whose question is given time to be spoken, and whose hands retain possession of a written page.

A distinctive feature of the arrangement is that the ancient scene does not dictate what happens in the modern one. Rahina's concrete claim for her wages need not await Udayana's answer; nor is the unsettled nature of his debate automatically resolved by the fact that Rahina loses work. The narrator creates reciprocal illumination, not causal unity, between the two eras. In this way the chapter offers a meaningful example of placing the novel's epic-philosophical chronology and contemporary local life within the same narrative system.

The Ancient Sequence: A Deferred Answer and Grief's Own Time

A fellow student of Udayana's visiting opponent died during the night. The visitor's pupil asks leave to depart from the assembly; Udayana's students might momentarily have mistaken the adversary's silence for an opportunity to argue. Udayana first decides to ascertain the visitor's wishes: a written reply may remain available, but it is improper to compel an absent person to speak through a page. The visitor brings the yellow

inkpot of his deceased friend; this is not a souvenir of scholarly disputation but private property to be returned to the family. Grief arrests the plot's movement, and the interruption changes the rules of dialogue.

A young student's question reveals an eagerness to extract an immediate ideological conclusion from a death. The visitor responds that his friend's death is a victory for neither his own side nor its opponents. Instead of delivering a doctrinal conclusion, the exchange sets a temporal limit on the right to demand speech. The attempt to turn death into a story of victory is stopped. Both the visitor and Udayana retain their positions, but the assembly adjourns out of respect for the grieving opponent. It is more useful to read the scene narratologically: the death marks a *pause in narration*, not the novel's final philosophical verdict on its subject.

An elderly woman who stitches manuscripts explains a practical way of separating the damp leaves. A young relative of the visitor's dead friend asks for the original signed page to be returned and raises the question of payment for copying. These two characters open the exclusive scene of celebrated intellectuals toward labour and a family's possession of objects. They have not come to select the winner of a debate; they wish to preserve pages and arrange household affairs. Thus the time of scholarly debate is not simply the "time of ideas." The household of the dead friend, the copyist, and the old craftswoman's physical work also constitute that scene.

At the last ancient meeting the visitor renews his question and Udayana answers, but no announcement declares that the deaths of innocent children or the problem of disorder have been resolved. A student is dissatisfied with the absence of a final conclusion, yet the page devoted to the answer leaves room for the opponent's disagreement. The decision is made to mention the dead friend's name only as far as his family wishes, and the visitor promises to bring his objections again. The "return" in the title therefore means the possibility of speaking once more after suspension, not the final settlement of controversy.

The Modern Sequence: The Cost of Testimony and Distance Within the Home

Rahina's opening of the shop is filled with the temporal demands of domestic life. A key stiffened by dew, two bundles withdrawn by customers, a cousin's letter, the hour for sending her daughter to school, and wages left unpaid from the preceding week impose the pressures of one morning in segments 10–11. In the earlier episode involving twenty-seven names, Rahina's statement and her limited knowledge of the order of copying were important. Now its consequences are made visible as a loss of livelihood. The author does not leave the act of speaking truthfully in an

inquiry as the final victory of principle; he shows how it changes the family business, a household's standing, and a child's education afterward.

Her brother speaks of the danger to the family's reputation; Rahina reads out the original limit of her statement: she supplied a receipt for her labour and did not declare that anyone knowingly removed words. This is the dispute's psychological centre. The brother-sister relationship does not immediately become enmity, but they value the same experience differently: his primary fear is losing customers, hers the trustworthiness of a copy and the worth of work done under her own name. The language of an inherited shop collides with that of livelihood. The author does not reduce a private relationship to a simple metaphor for an ethical debate; the actual withdrawal of customers' bundles is an independent event in the plot.

Rama comes seeking not a public spectacle but a limited supplementary statement. Rahina links that request to her loss of earnings. Two applications are prepared: one for the investigative copy, the other for unpaid dues and service-related loss. Her brother insists that customers' names not be disclosed without permission; Rahina proposes recording the numbers and dates of jobs instead. In the supplementary statement she prevents something she heard from being described as something she saw. The result is not complete family reconciliation: there is an agreement to recount some of the bundles, but her statement is not withdrawn. The narrative's sensitivity lies in this incomplete outcome.

Focalisation, Interruption, and the Narrator's Restraint

In the ancient sequence the focus moves from Udayana's page to the visitor's inkpot, the student's embarrassment, and the elderly woman's hands. In the modern sequence it rests on Rahina's wet key, her daughter, her brother's lowered gaze, Rama's limited application, and a woman street-vendor saving her papers. The third-person narrator connects the scenes without announcing a final judgment like an omniscient moral judge. In particular, the death that interrupts the ancient debate has already occurred; the narrator does not fabricate an extensive scene of the last night, but shows the mourners' responses. This unshown death leaves an emotional vacancy within the story.

There is a subtle parallel in narrative duration. The ancient assembly pauses to respect the visitor's physical and mental time after a death; the modern shopkeeper reserves time to send her daughter to school despite the tensions of her family. In both settings an “answer” is deferred, but deferral is not escape. Rahina later gives her testimony again and her brother agrees to count unfinished work; the visitor resumes the dispute.

This positive reconstruction of delay is a temporal achievement of the narrative.

The Symbolic Sequence of Pages, Keys, Thread, and Shadows

Two leaves in the ancient study stick together when wet; the old woman places a thin dry leaf between them. In the modern lane, a copied sheet falls from a cart and adheres near the drain; Rahina patiently retrieves it while her brother supports the cart. This visual echo is carefully constructed. The first sheet is the written form of a disagreement; the second is an instrument for recording cloth measurements and a craftsperson's wages. While saving both, the people involved set aside their immediate quarrels and work together. Yet their cooperation does not dissolve the earlier disagreement. The artistic strength of the image lies in its incompleteness.

The key becomes an image of the double enclosure connecting home and shop in the modern section. In the final modern scene, the shadows of four files appear as a single blot, but when Rama straightens the glass around the lamp, the shadows separate again. This image explicitly converses with the fourfold reflection of a wall in the water at the end of Chapter 138. The water-reflection had shown a disorderly visual division; the lamplight briefly creates the illusion that all the files are one. Through repetition the narrator shifts the metaphor into a new setting and illumination, changing its meaning.

Critical Assessment

The chapter's finest achievement is its restrained use of intertextuality across two periods. Udayana's debate does not deliver a philosophical lesson to Rahina's modern life; in both narratives, listening, stopping, speaking again, naming labour, and determining rights over a copy unfold in different ways. The ancient craftswoman's stitching hands and the modern copyist's wet sheet interrupt the monopoly of famous philosophical figures. The author's structural courage consists in allowing numerous important questions to remain undecided without leaving the reader with a sense of an unfinished chapter. Narrative completeness is located not in a decision, but in preserving the time necessary for disagreement.

The limitation is equally evident. Even in adversity Udayana and the visitor speak in a highly ordered, modern language attentive to consent; this sometimes diminishes the distinction between their historical lifeworlds. The resonances between the ancient debate and the modern statement are so meaningful that certain scenes risk appearing to be prearranged parallel lessons. Nevertheless, falling lime, the inkpot, the labour of retrieving paper from a drain, and the act of sending a daughter

to school introduce living irregularity into the excessive design. In narratological terms the chapter succeeds: grief halts dialogue for a time, but does not abolish the future of questioning.

Chapter 140 — Action and Cause

The Arrival of a Fifth Register: A Decisive Shift in the Story's Centre

The first scene of "Action and Cause" connects directly with the modern ending of the preceding chapter. Drops fall from the ceiling of the veranda at dawn; beside the four inquiry files Gomati draws a fifth register toward herself, devoted to wages and dues. The arrival of this fifth object enlarges the plot. Earlier the possible causes of the accident were separated; now the question is how payment to living people can proceed while the inquiry continues. When her own claim for eight loads of earth is reviewed, Gomati does not wish to use the convenor's chair for private advantage. This small indication of inward caution reveals a central character who is not merely "an official performing duty" but a person situated within conflicting interests.

A departmental letter circles one worker's attendance number even though many people have signed the materials, plans, and inspection papers. Outside, his child calls him "Babu," while his wife carries an empty bag for rice and speaks of mounting interest on their debt. The two adjacent textual segments are structurally important: in one, the person is an official number; in the other, he has a family name, bodily wounds, and economic time. The narrator places both forms within a single visual sequence so that the reader recognises that the archival designation and lived experience are not the same perspective.

Raghav's Story: Reputation, Family, and the Independence of Testimony

With the arrival of Raghav Singh, the chapter extends from the office table to the factory yard. He acknowledges his role in the lease and supplies but does not automatically assume responsibility for quality inspection of repairs. Having seen the correctness of the first statement, his nephew restricts his account to his own handwriting and the time he personally observed; he does not know who filled the blank portion of the file later. The narrator does not turn the nephew into the uncomplicated victorious figure of "a brave young man who told the truth." His independent account puts pressure on the family's work and economic relations.

A telephone call informs Raghav that a previously suspended collaboration has now been terminated. The business loss becomes more concrete, but the narrator does not assume that the contract was necessarily cancelled in retaliation for the nephew's testimony. The dates and earlier call are recorded separately. Raghav arranges the account of wages still owed to workers in the factory; his sister insists that the nephew not be blamed for

the entire business loss. Three narrative positions consequently emerge within one character: supplier, owner struggling with commercial losses, and uncle of the witness. Raghav's decision is not an absolute moral transformation, but a shifting priority among the market, personal honour, and workers' dues.

In the evening he submits a formal letter stating that his nephew's testimony will no longer be privately restricted and that attendance wages will not be cut because of it. A limited condition remains: individual salaries and workers' names should not be made public unnecessarily. The factory's financial crisis does not end, but the independence of the statement becomes a specific achievement of the narrative. The nephew, too, reads a copy of his uncle's words and agrees to a correction in his own voice. This is not full restoration of the relationship, but a stage in acknowledging the boundaries of one another's statements.

Shashi's Two Keys: A Crack in the Uniform Story of Ownership

Shashi Mahuri arrives with two brass keys, a lease contract, rent receipts, an objection to a second lock installed without permission, and a copy of the watchman's attendance register. The composition of objects in this entrance is precise. Keys seem to signify authority to open a warehouse, but two rings, a crooked door leaf, and distinct locks reveal inequality of access. Shashi owns the building, yet has not witnessed what occurred in every room on every night. The narrator introduces an inner inconsistency into a single word such as “owner”: the building, rent, rear passage, and goods under investigation are distinct matters.

The watchman says Shekhar once asked him for a key at night and he refused; he did not see whether someone used the other gate. Parvati, a woman labourer, states that she was paid for drying her wet sacks, but counting the goods in the back room was not her work. Neither limited account becomes a “collective statement” added in Shashi's defence. Shashi herself tries not to assume ownership of the watchman's words. This is a particular narrative achievement: even after Shashi enters the scene, peripheral workers do not become mere confirmations of her inward consciousness.

Two ink lines on the rear access route, the unknown date of an alteration, and the condition of the sealed room remain unresolved. Shashi is willing to pay rent again, but receives no permission to open the room under investigation without an order from a competent authority. The keys are once more kept apart. The recurrence of these objects yields the chapter's conclusion: formal unity of ownership is not unity of actual rights of access in the story.

The Earthworker's Home: Domestic Time Within a Public Event

The chapter began with the worker's cracked palm, his wife's empty rice bag, and the time measured by interest on debt. In its latter half, the wife and child wait; the child wants to make a paper boat out of his father's receipt, and his mother stops him. This domestic scene is especially effective. An official slip might have been an object of play for the child, but for his mother it is the only object with which to demand a reply by a particular date. The narrator makes two meanings of the same paper immediately visible: an administrative instrument of the plot and a family's small future. Later the child receives a piece of blank newspaper for his boat; the object's meaning changes, but the payment remains incomplete.

An independent payment verifier **recommends** releasing the undisputed portion of wages; no full sum is distributed immediately. Gomati entrusts her claim for eight loads to a different committee member. These small decisions clarify the narrative meaning of "work" in the novel's Shanti Parva: some concrete progress has occurred, but public suffering has not reached a complete end. The worker voices a suspicious accusation that Gomati is protecting her own people; she does not silence him with rebuke. Disagreement survives, and therefore the scene does not turn into a declaration of the heroine's victory.

Narrative Time, Shifts of Place, and Multiple Centres of Vision

The story follows a line from dawn to night in one day. The movements from office to factory and back, to waiting on the veranda and a window in darkness create both pauses in time and intensified activity. The same day passes at different speeds for different people: news of a terminated contract is sudden for Raghav; fear of interest due the following week is a longstanding crisis for the worker's wife; the old two keys now define a revised security boundary for Shashi; for Sarita, Naira's death is an already certain grief, though questions of private papers and unfinished work remain open. The narrator does not attempt to compress all these times into the clock of one office.

Focalisation does not remain inside Gomati. Raghav looking toward a dark factory room, the watchman repeatedly blinking in daylight, Parvati's insistence on keeping her market-day work, the worker's cracked palm, and Sarita sitting silently in a chair extend the sensory range of the narrative. The experiences of marginal characters are not merely raw material for the solution of a single protagonist. Nevertheless, the principal formulation of official sentences remains with Gomati and Rama; widening focalisation does not give all characters equal narrative

duration. This inequality is both a realistic limit and a structural tension in the work.

A Chain of Symbols: Attendance Number, Two Keys, Fifth Register, and Boat

The physical arrangement in which a fifth register of dues is added to four files of allegations links the chapter's beginning and ending. The worker's number is not a symbol of an unknown person but the actual registered form of his labour; his child's word "Babu" makes the number's lived relationships visible. The absence of Raghav's empty cardboard box and the presence of a thick envelope image a transition from the supply story of the industrial sequence to the letter-centred story of Uttara Kanda. Shashi's keys mark her limited right of physical access to a seized site. In the last scene the child's newspaper boat pauses in a little whirlpool before moving toward the bank; Gomati does not infer the cause of the accident from the boat's movement. This is a self-aware scene: however meaningful a metaphor may be, it cannot establish an undecided fact in the plot.

In the final textual segment a relief receipt, a written reply, and a notice of legal proceedings create three distinct threads leading into the future. The narrator gives the reader a small, explicit anticipation of the coming chapter, "Help and Litigation." There is no court verdict yet, but a date has been set by which an individual must answer for a duty. Through this distinction the chapter reaches its restricted climax.

Achievement and Artistic Limitation

The literary achievement of "Action and Cause" lies in joining arguments about multiple causes to events such as Raghav's actual commercial loss, the nephew's independent speech, Shashi's two keys, and the worker's wife's rice bag, rather than leaving them as exposition. Contradictory roles remain alive within a person known by a single name. Raghav wishes to protect his reputation but cannot suppress workers' dues; Shashi claims rights as a landlord without claiming to know events she did not see; Gomati is convenor but not adjudicator of her own payment. The characters' moral credibility arises here not from official identities, but from small decisions that change over time.

The principal limitation is that several characters speak in a surprisingly similar analytical rhythm. Harivad's perspective almost automatically turns into finely drawn distinctions, while a judicious concluding exchange between Gomati and Rama is nearly obligatory. The extraordinary uncertainties of social events are at times hidden under prearranged administrative clarity. Even so, the private obstinacy of Raghav's sister, the nephew's uncomfortable silence, the child's paper boat,

and Sarita's unheroic, wordless sitting give the story sensuous depth. Among this sequence of four chapters, Chapter 140 brings the largest number of conflicting narratives of ordinary life onto a single stage.

Shanti Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 137–140

From Correction to Distinct Voices: The Sequence of Four Chapters

The order of these four chapters creates a recognisable narrative arc. Chapter 137 publicly withdraws Aditi's earlier statement and establishes four possible questions; Chapter 138 introduces the experiences of workers, bereaved families, and separate dues into those four files; Chapter 139 brings the dual-temporal parallel of Udayana's ancient encounter with a visitor and Rahina's modern copying shop into this divided contemporary narrative; and Chapter 140 opens a fifth register for dues, connecting the investigation to the real time of work and household livelihood. The decisive movement is **correcting an old account → separating several possible accounts of an event → creating a new arrangement for listening → the economic afterlife of responsibility**. This is not a story that ends with the discovery of a criminal.

The narrative time of the four chapters contains three days of modern office work and one chapter spanning two periods. Chapters 137, 138, and 140 establish tangible morning–afternoon–evening sequences in the modern stream; Chapter 139 alternates between Udayana's ancient chamber and Rahina's shop in 2040. No modern character possesses knowledge of the ancient scenes; their relationship is constructed at the level of comparison by the reader. Because these narrative levels remain clear, the ancient debate does not become the source of the modern committee's judicial authority. Instead it deepens the ethical dimensions of narration: both the dead friend's family and Rahina's family claim the right to their different forms of time.

Recurring Objects and Narrative Memory

The old measuring scale and original report, four empty files, Udayana's stuck palm leaves, Rahina's jammed key, Shashi's two brass keys, and the carefully preserved receipt of the worker's wife summon earlier experiences without delivering an explanation to the reader. Sheets are rescued in two periods, but in the ancient scene they preserve the writing of contested positions, whereas in the modern scene they record sewing measurements and wages for craft labour. Chapter 138's broken reflection in water becomes in Chapter 139 a file-shadow that first merges into a blot and then separates again. The recurrence of objects gives the narrative an inner rhythm of memory; that rhythm keeps the four chapters' long office conversations from becoming wholly monotonous.

Distinct Character Voices and Unequal Narrative Space

Gomati and Rama repeatedly occupy the centre, but Aditi, Tara, Mamta, Rani, Paro, Rahina, Raghav, Shashi, Kabir, and Sarita change the scenes through their own experiences. Mamta preserves an earlier written objection; Rahina demands an accounting of work rather than withdrawing her statement; Raghav decides not to control his nephew's testimony; and Parvati chooses a hearing date that protects the work she does on market days. These specific desires create concrete conditions for polyphony. Nevertheless, every character states the limits of their experience very clearly. Greater use of ambiguous exchanges, confused recollections, and impatient, unfinished sentences could have brought important differences into such an expansive fictional world.

Principal Achievement, Counterargument, and the Impulse Toward the Next Plot

The finest achievement of these four chapters is that Shanti Parva does not turn governance after mourning into a story of successful reconstruction alone. Committee decisions do not settle the whole of social life. The old report is withdrawn, but new measurements remain unfinished; allegations are separated, but responsibility is not determined; an ancient dispute resumes, but agreement is absent; release of the undisputed part of wages is recommended, but full payment has not occurred. The date fixed for an answer in the last chapter is a tangible change in everyday life, not a judicial verdict. Such an open outcome gives a possible justification to the long structure of Uttara Kanda.

Its main structural risk, however, is repetition. In chapter after chapter, separate registers, limited agreements, unresolved answers, and letters promised for the next day recur in a similar pattern. For the aesthetics of non-resolution to remain meaningful, the cost of delay, the nature of the persons concerned, and the particular setting must continue to change. In these four chapters Rahina's daughter, Mamta's household book, the workers in Raghav's factory, the child wanting to make a boat from his father's receipt, and Sarita's grief provide the necessary variety. The final question preparing the next chapter, “Help and Litigation,” is clear: how will the separate narrative arcs of assistance and conflict affect one another without either erasing the other's right to be told?

Chapter 141 — Help and Litigation

A Chest on Wet Stone: A New Narrative Object in Shanti Parva

“Help and Litigation” begins with an iron chest. Placed on damp stone at the steps of the committee room, it bears the words “medical assistance” in faded paint; inside are receipts, medicine slips, and an empty cloth bag. This introduction could have been a simple prelude to a story of relief, but before the chest is brought inside Rama asks about permission from the person who left it and acknowledgment of its receipt. Meaning is generated here not by a lesson added after the event but by the order in which an object enters the scene: first the chest, then the keys, then the donor, and finally a family whose life bears the shadows of both assistance and violence. At first the reader encounters the object's social category, “help”; the characters' conduct gradually puts its narrative role into dispute.

Rameshwar holds two keys to the chest. Recalling Shashi's two keys in Chapter 140 and the bunch of keys Ruhani will hold in Chapter 143, the reader sees that a key has no stable symbolic meaning in Uttara Kanda. Shashi's keys raised questions of property and access; here the keys ask about the donor's limits of control over an object; in the shelter they will become instruments for the decentralisation of administration. The same metal acquires different meanings because it returns with different people and decisions. This recurrence of objects creates continuity between chapters while preserving the physical particularity of each incident.

Register of Events: From the Public Display of Charity to Rejection of a Waiver

The first main action is Devvrat's presentation of an account of assistance and Kabir's raising of questions about Mahesh's death. A draft appears under the heading “Protection on Grounds of Recognition for Social Service.” Devvrat does not immediately confess to a criminal offence, nor does Kabir deny the value of the assistance he gave. The conflict does not arise from reducing the two to good and bad; it concerns the distance between a benefactor's social prestige and the victim's independent room to tell a story. Mahesh's wife arrives with her daughter and refuses to appear jointly before the main table, choosing a separate room. That decision changes the arrangement of space: beside the debate at the main table a room is established in which the bereaved family controls the timing of its own speech.

At the second stage, Rama distinguishes the hospital's receipt of assistance from the warehouse's record of its dispatch. Devvrat admits an earlier

numerical correction, but the final use of the goods still requires reconciliation. Shabnam Malik's arrival turns the narrative in another direction: an unauthorised nameplate was used to secure access to a file. An employee acknowledges having seen three covers, but cannot say with certainty whether he saw their contents. This episode is independent of the question of Devvrat's assistance, yet it visibly reveals the danger of the same public vocabulary of charitable prestige and rights of access. Shabnam does not treat the misuse of her surname merely as a matter of personal honour; she demands a concrete place for her dissent in the record.

In the third stage, Mahendra Mahaseth and Binod Jaiswal arrive with two different account books. An identical seal at an intermediary transport counter does not make their businesses one; the purchases, dates, and ownership are corrected separately. This brief incident does not resolve the principal litigation. It dismantles the conflation of people's lives on the basis of identical names. Later it ends in an image of the two going toward a different lane. Pinning up the correction does not erase the ink of the former public accusation. This final image limits the potentially overoptimistic meaning of the word “correction.”

The fourth and most decisive change is the discovery of a sentence printed within the receipt form: “no further claim.” A receipt acknowledging goods and a renunciation of future claims have been forced onto the same sheet. The field for the identity of the person present beside a woman's thumbprint is blank; the narrator does not immediately convert that blank into a finding of guilt. From the separate room Mahesh's wife says she will inspect the record of receiving assistance, but will not give her statement about the death at a donor's ceremony. Later, rather than immediately acknowledge the old thumbprint as hers, she demands to see the original sheet. Across these interventions, her character develops not by awaiting another's permission, but by practising the right to decide the conditions under which she will speak.

The unpaid dues of Rukhsana's kitchen, Sarita's account of confirming Naira's death, Urmila's outstanding wages, and the confidentiality of individual treatment files enter the room's discussion. Gomati finally signs three separate letters: reconciliation of assistance continues; independent examination of the waiver clause continues; investigation of Mahesh's death continues before the competent authority. Producing these three documents is an actual outcome at the level of events. A final judicial determination of crime, the origin of the earlier thumbprint, and complete reconciliation of the medicine's route do not occur here. Thus the ending is characterised not by a declaration of success but by the survival of distinct lines of narrative.

Narrative Time, Changes of Scene, and the Bereaved Family's Private Time

The chapter's external duration reaches from the placing of the chest in the morning to the closing of the door in the evening. Mahesh's earlier threats, death, medical assistance, and previous dispatches of goods are reintroduced through present conversation. These retrospections occur not as extended flashback scenes but through displaying earlier letters and a family's brief recollections. Extended office dialogues alternate with short summaries of receipts and correspondence. After an indication of evening in segment 18, the scene of opening the chest occurs in segment 23 under the phrase “after the afternoon had passed.” Rather than necessarily treating this as a temporal contradiction, it is more accurate to recognise a slight looseness in chronology: the author uses explicit time markers while joining different sequences, but their coordination is not everywhere equally strict.

The third-person narrator moves mostly around Rama and Gomati's administrative table, yet the scenes with Mahesh's wife and daughter shift focalisation. The child's blue bag, the mother's repeated adjustment of its ribbon, and the daughter's drawing of two houses—one with a door and the other with a window—form a sensory language for private fear amid institutional debate. Both doors in the drawing stand open. This does not represent victory in a lawsuit but visually suggests that the bereaved family's options have not been closed. Sarita looks not at the chest of assistance but toward the wet road, protecting the character's private world of time rather than putting grief at the centre of a spectacle.

Polyphony, Recurring Objects, and Assessment

Devvrat's complexity is an important achievement of the chapter. He is confident in his acts of assistance; initially he is uncomfortable that scrutiny should come before recognition of his social merit. At the end he abandons the old draft concerning “protection” and agrees to supply records, while reserving his right to a defence. Kabir prevents this statement by an adversary from being incorrectly recorded as “an admission of crime.” His insistence on giving another's words their proper limits marks an important stage in Kabir's development: mourning Naira's death does not reduce his language to a single impulse toward vengeance. Rama and Gomati's decisions are not unassailable ideal administration either. The real outcomes are scattered among letters, hearings, and replies expected on subsequent days, with no certainty that they will all be completed.

The network of recurring objects is carefully formed: the iron chest, two keys, open and closed rooms, a revealed thumbprint, Sarita's empty hands,

and an ink mark that remains. These relationships give the social story of “help” an equal place beside that of “litigation.” Yet a risk to the artistry remains: many characters enter and make exactly the distinction the scene needs, while the narrator promptly sorts each utterance into its proper category. The nuanced disagreement between Devvrat and Kabir produces genuine living tension; by contrast, some subordinate officials' instantly erroneous labels become comparatively schematic teaching scenes. Nevertheless, the restraint of the scenes with the wife and daughter, the smoke from Rukhsana's cooking rice, and the two traders departing into another lane place this procedural prose back within the unequal times of life. The final question turns toward the source of the medicines; that is the causal opening of Chapter 142, not an unexpected twist from outside the story.

Chapter 142 — The Source of the Medicines

The Arrangement of Three Boxes: Many Routes Within One Room

"The Source of the Medicines" opens with three boxes in the temporary hospital's medicine room: a blue strip for approved stock, the donor's red ink, and a third box without a name. The colour scheme might have served a straightforward mystery—what criminal secret does a box contain?—but Salma photographs the third box while its seal is intact and separates the ongoing treatment using verified medicines. The room is not simply a hospital backdrop: doors, seals, storage, and medical contact determine the plot's movement. The decision not to open the box brings one part of the story to a halt, but the time required for treating patients cannot be suspended. The chapter develops tension between these two tempos.

Chapter 141's closing question—where did each consignment come from?—changes its setting into Chapter 142's first medicine room. The sequence is tightly constructed: the uncertain slip in the preceding chapter's iron assistance chest now unfolds into three distinct covers, a stock book, and a receipt register at the hospital. The author does not extract a sensational criminal from a secret chamber; some goods are marked safe, others useful, and others still incompletely identified. The sense of mystery develops not through the immediate revelation of a culprit, but through the divergent documentary journeys of goods said to have followed a single route.

Register of Events: From Eight and Nine Bundles to Four Distinct Actions

The first turn is the discrepancy between nine bundles on the purchase slip and eight in the receipt register. A clerk immediately wants to construct a story of theft; Salma keeps the possible routes of transport, a patient transfer, and returns open. Aniruddha remembers that one bundle may have gone with a patient, but does not elevate his recollection into a complete account. Memory is thus important to the narration without becoming an omniscient key to the plot. Aniruddha's injured left hand, and Salma's refusal to let him sit behind her desk, make the shift in medical leadership visible through the arrangement of bodies, not merely through a statement about authority.

The second turn is the arrival of Meena Sah's metal container. She brings a workshop sample, an old invoice, and wages half withheld. An officer wants to read the entire history of medicine distribution from the phrase "medical container"; Meena explains its narrower meaning: a bill for

repairs to the container does not identify what was placed inside. The old construction methods involving lime and shell enter this dispute. Even where work on metal, lime, and medicine occurred on the same date, the story does not immediately transform all of it into one conspiracy. Aditi brings her corrected earlier report, Lalit explains the local identification of old building materials, and the scene of sample testing progresses. The author moves the crisis narrative away from a single feverish search for a cause into the experiences of diverse kinds of labour.

The third turn is Vibha Agrahari's supply account, which separately records purchase price, transport, cold storage, and profit. Vibha has already held back a box with a mismatched label; public rumour associates her with hoarding. She is not simply a symbol of an innocent trader. She agrees that profit margins may be examined, but does not wish the driver's wages or the cost of preserving medicines to be treated as zero. The level of voice shifts here from Meena to Vibha: the particular labour of a metalworker and the commercial time of a medicine distributor cannot be absorbed into one general word, "medicine."

The fourth turn is the order to release four sacks belonging to Rahim Mansuri that have been withheld. A long period of time enters directly amid the rhythm of relief: three journeys to appeal, the expense of obtaining copies, the death of a customer, and four months during which his daughter has waited. The withdrawal of an allegation is a real change in his situation, but elapsed time cannot be returned. At the end Rahim and Vibha's driver place different slips in the same vehicle. The vehicle is again shared space, but the narrative identities of its contents remain separate. This brief scene informally rebuts the earlier public accusations and illusions of association.

The last decisive change is the preparation of four orders: continued supply of verified medicines, a source inquiry into the doubtful consignment, separate steps concerning the dues of Meena and Rahim, and site-specific testing of the lime-and-shell sample. A clerk wants to write "medicine case closed"; Gomati instead has the words "treatment continuing, source inquiry continuing" entered. The two occurrences of "continuing" form the chapter's structural principle. Clinical time and investigative time both move forward, yet neither completely controls the other. Safe medicines leave by vehicle, the four sacks are returned, and Meena receives a copy of the wage order; the unnamed third box remains sealed. The results are multiple, not a total resolution.

Time and Space, Focalisation, and Death in Absence

The principal story is a one-day journey from dawn to dusk through the medicine room, veranda, warehouse, another meeting, and road. Yet the

objects present bring several significant past times into the scene: Aniruddha's former decision, the night of Jamuna Devi's treatment, an unsafe route through the building, Rahim's four months, Meena's identification of another vessel, and the deaths of Naira and Urmila. This past is presented chiefly through dialogue and limited recollection; the chapter contains no independent scene from the Mahabharata or another ancient period. The narrator does not remain fixed in Aniruddha's consciousness but shifts between Salma's orders in the present, Meena's professional pride, Vibha's market anxieties, and Rahim's prolonged exhaustion from appeals.

Rahim's old pillowcase is a distinctive object of memory. The daughter of a dead customer is waiting for the return of the bedding; this scene connects the institutional answer concerning four released sacks to a dead person's intimate domestic remnant. Through a window Aniruddha sees a boy giving water to his father, and the present image opens a path of memory toward an earlier day of treatment. The narrator does not turn this mental return into the dead person's voice or an authoritative reconstruction of the incident. The grief of Stri Parva has not disappeared; it acquires a new place among bodily protection, delay, and the obligations of those who remain alive.

Polyphony, the Last Key, and Artistic Counterargument

Salma, Aniruddha, Rama, Gomati, Meena, Vibha, Rahim, Lalit, Aditi, and Ruhani carry several social languages. Their number alone does not establish polyphony; it becomes vivid when the characters express the otherwise missing costs of their lives. Meena refuses to treat the first wage payment as a gift in return for testimony. Vibha includes drivers' wages and medicine security in her calculations. Rahim speaks of appeal expenses and the household's long waiting. Ruhani raises the question of separating the right to receive medicine from her possession of the only key. These are not necessarily competing goals, but forms of coexistence among different lived times.

Its artistic limitation nonetheless remains clear. The narrator repeatedly gives strong characters very exact distinctions in nearly identical formulations: this is separate, that is separate; this continues, that continues. Such systematically recurrent sentences can diminish the disordered sounds of hospital urgency, fear for patients, and workers' distress. The dramatic entrance of two or three boxes might create tension, but the accumulation of auxiliary characters sometimes turns the scene into the reading of files. Even so, Aniruddha's left hand, Rahim's pillowcase, Meena's demonstration of a sample, and the evening vehicle with separate destinations constrain that risk. The last line—"there was

one key in the shelter, but many needs”—directly plants the narrative seed of Chapter 143.

Chapter 143 — The Shelter's Rules

From a Jammed Key to a Collective Decision: The Story of an Institution Within an Object

The first action in "The Shelter's Rules" is a lock turning twice and the key jamming on the third attempt. This is not merely a technical defect. Ruhani holds a bunch containing the keys to the gate, store, medicine chest, and rear room. Such an opening reminds the reader of "Ruhani's Key" from earlier chapters and of Chapter 142's last question. The practical authority that saved lives during an emergency may now obstruct many daily necessities when concentrated in one person. The author does not present the difference as the sudden revelation of Ruhani's moral failure; the physical experience of the jammed key makes the need for change felt.

The shelter's four pages—gate, store, treatment, and complaints—become a new intimate map of its narrative arrangement. Unlike the four files of allegations or the hospital's three boxes, they are not simply instruments of an external committee. They contain questions about how a household's daily work should proceed, who has the right to speak inside, and whose private history should remain confidential. The narrator first shows an immediate dispute between Ruhani and Rukhsana; when Zubaida sets down a sheet of paper, that disagreement becomes a scene of collective decision. Ruhani's question travels from "I can open the lock" to "will the work continue if I am absent?" This marks a genuine change in perspective, not merely a speech.

Register of Events: Four Pages, Two Disputes, and a Transfer of Keys

At the first stage a young woman needing confidential medication asks whether the three members of a proposed committee will all be able to read the page describing her illness. She is not obliged to identify herself publicly. Champa raises another question: may someone who works at the shelter but does not live there speak in decisions, and must residents disclose their private lives before voting? The story thus opens the new institutional meeting not as a celebration of consent, but as a dispute among different vulnerabilities. Ruhani proposes separate representation for residents and regular workers, medical confidentiality, and restricted emergency access. A proposal is not immediate acceptance; the discussion ahead changes its practical shape.

The second stage begins with the entry of Rani Halalkhor's team. Rani's torn sandal strap, the hours register, and the mouth of a blocked drain put the need for safe accommodation beside the risks of cleaning work in the same courtyard. The residents' question—if the drain is not opened, will

water enter the house?—is serious; Rani's reply opens the issue of danger to her own body and the distinct time required for her work. The chapter does not make her a character who always refuses. The team is given time to consider safe outdoor cleaning, while the interior blocked drain remains a separate task. Safe external cleaning is eventually completed, but the cause of the interior blockage remains unresolved. This incompleteness keeps the process of making shelter rules within the limits of its real physical site.

The third stage concerns Madhav Rauniyar's defective packing materials and confused entries in the invoices for the shelter's cupboards. Madhav decides not to impose the loss of a rejected shipment on the shelter, but also refuses a distributor's demand that he keep silent in his future business dealings. The episode may seem distant from the central dispute over keys, yet it demonstrates that the independent decisions of an outside craftsperson cannot be appropriated in the name of the shelter's welfare. Ruhani may serve as a witness, not become owner of Madhav's shop. This structuring of difference makes Ruhani's decision to relinquish the keys a relationship tested in practice, not merely a private emotion.

The fourth stage is voting and transfer. Rukhsana asks for fixed store hours, two responsible persons present, and written receipts for withdrawals. An elderly woman fears that the gate will remain shut during an emergency. Champa demands an alternative process where a representative is herself the subject of a complaint. The rules are adopted by a majority; Zubaida becomes a representative and Rukhsana takes responsibility at night. Two members' dissent concerning payment for guarding and the privacy of a room remains in the voting register. Ruhani places the keys in Zubaida's palm and writes “member” after her own name. The change of this single word is the new institution's densest visual outcome: the character changes through signing and naming an office, not through the force of a speech.

Narrative Time, Spatial Time, and the Emergence of New Characters

The main duration extends from a jammed key at dawn to voting in the evening and cleaning the floor the following morning. Memories repeatedly uncover previous nights in the shelter, unpaid wages for safe cleaning, the distributor's earlier slip, the time Ruhani opened the gate in a crisis, and private injuries. They do not become independent old narrative periods but enter present dialogue and Ruhani's momentary introspection. The narrator writes in the third person, yet Ruhani's fear of losing control makes her the mental centre. At the same time Rani's sandal, Madhav's bag, the young woman's confidential question, and Rukhsana's hearth distribute focalisation among the characters.

Place is crucially significant. Boundaries such as the shelter gate and medicine room concern safe admission, but the rear drain and a potential classroom for the girl are places where rules alone cannot assure safety without measurements or an inspection of repairs. In the final scene the girl's question about learning to read appears. The new representative acknowledges the limits of her authority and records the question for the next meeting. The first visible result of representation is thus not the mere establishment of a committee, but the writing down of a child's question. The preceding chapter's conclusion gives birth to the next chapter, "The Question of Work."

Domestic Labour, Women's Voices, and the Narrative's Achievements and Limits

The meeting is scheduled after cooking hours so that, in Rukhsana's words, "the rice must not remain half-cooked." This ordinary adjustment of time becomes the chapter's central narrative principle: the time of public decision must change to accommodate the labour of a woman who prepares food. Rani's refusal of unsafe work, Champa's privacy, Madhav's commercial independence, and Zubaida's elected role gradually decentralise Ruhani's previously singular position through the voices of four distinct characters. "Polyphony" here is not the absorption of all voices into a representative's speech, but the preservation of qualified dissent in the voting register.

The chapter's limits must also be examined critically. Many questions are answered in extraordinarily considered formulations of rules; amid exhaustion, fear of violence, and the daily struggles of a temporary shelter, the characters' precise language sometimes resembles a manifesto rather than spontaneous conversation. Madhav's defective shipment story extends somewhat away from the central pivot of the key, although its necessary connection to preserving the outside craftsperson's ownership is present in the text. The tension of disagreement is strongest in Rani's torn sandal, Ruhani's momentary hesitation, and the girl's damp notebook. The chapter achieves its effect because creating rules does not erase previous harm: the interior drain remains blocked, old wages are unpaid, the dispute with the distributor is incomplete, and the answer to the girl's question about schooling awaits the following day.

Chapter 144 — The Question of Work

A Piece of Chalk and a Child's Question: Shanti Parva's Narrative Epilogue

"The Question of Work" opens at dawn with Zubaida feeling half a piece of chalk pressing painfully against her foot. The child's question about learning to read from the preceding chapter now returns as a physical examination of the place. Lime falling from the ceiling, a damp notebook, and a dark line left by earlier moisture prevent the shelter's new classroom from becoming merely a celebration of triumph. Instead of the hazardous interior room, Zubaida chooses a veranda and an empty porch. This decision makes room for both the desire for education and the condition of the building. Before declaring that "a school has opened," the narrator shows where it must not open. This negative decision about space is itself a concrete event, because it prevents children from sitting in an unsafe room.

On this day Ruhani attends as a member of the assembly, not as its former sole authority. The transfer of keys has a consequence in the actual conduct of the story. Rukhsana can join the meeting after the first pot of food has been prepared, because the wages of the two women cooking it have been separately recorded. Answering a question about education is a major decision for a community, but its basis is a small arrangement of domestic time. Shanti Parva has reached from postwar decisions about government to the story of everyday social reconstruction.

Sequence of Events: Entry, Lessons, Festival, and the Next Ration Crisis

The first stage is a dispute about conditions of admission. Padma's bag contains instructions in three languages, papers, and a bell. Sanket brings a recording device but restricts its use without permission to make voices public. An elderly person proposes first priority for shelter residents; a teenager who has come from outside with a handcart asks whether he will be stopped at the gate if he comes to learn. Padma separates the opportunity to study from proof of residence while also protecting the internal privacy of the shelter. In this scene "inclusion" does not remain an empty word of praise; it becomes a practical question of place, time, and admission. Sanket's display of examples involving raised surfaces, shapes, hearing, and touch lets the reader see different sensory experiences of education. The narrative itself also acknowledges that for some people these models will be inadequate.

The second stage concerns mourning and privacy. Sarita brings not Naira's private notebook but a blank ruled sheet of her own. The girl asks whether Naira's writing can be read aloud. Sarita maintains her decision not to make private writing public, while accepting that the courage to ask questions can be taught. Looking at a bowl, Kabir imagines how Naira might have responded; the narrator does not convert his imagination into Naira's actual words. A young girl asks whether a dead person can teach again. Sarita explains plainly that death cannot be undone, although something learned may remain alive. Here the author avoids the temptation to transform the afterlife of grief into a miraculous victory for education. Naira's presence-in-absence survives in objects and memory, not in a new supernatural occurrence.

The third stage introduces objects brought by Irfan Khan and Harish Pansari. Irfan delivers a bench in a safe vehicle; he had lost business because he refused to drive a customer's vehicle with defective brakes. The gift of the bench and the actual wages for transport are separately accounted for; he does not recover the loss of customers from the classroom. Harish has held back a consignment with wrongly printed packaging but sells a verified box of chalk at its price. A teenager asks whether damage to a seller's name also makes real chalk defective. The question joins the trader's tarnished identity to the present quality of an object. The two episodes broaden the meaning of "work" beyond the teacher's classroom into social life.

The fourth stage is a Phagun gathering of public reading, open accounts, and songs. Payment for singing time, kitchen work, safe cleaning wages, and consent for using equipment are separately recorded. An official wants to merge all the costs under "festival"; Zubaida prevents the different times of labour from being erased. Meanwhile songs, drawings, short exchanges, and children's laughter change the story's pace. A child draws a running flatbread with six legs, explaining that his mother makes bread so fast that it disappears even faster. Rukhsana laughs in her reply. The scene introduces spontaneous conversational humour, quite unlike the earlier vocabulary of files. Play can find a place in life even while grief continues.

The fifth and final sequence is the actual opening of the classroom and preparation for the next dispute over rations. At the first lesson a bowl, a receipt, and a measuring cord are set out, and children offer their own interpretations. The need for young people's night-watch duties leads to two short classes, one at dawn and another in the evening. An elderly woman asks for a way to understand the decision herself instead of hearing it only from her grandson. The group practises keeping the exit safe. A child reads his own name and asks if he may return tomorrow. Here the story makes the beginning of education not a slogan but an actual

possibility of coming back. At the end, discrepancies appear in the spelling on two ration slips and the new address of one family. Beneath the girl's first question, “Can I read?”, is an answer written in her own hand; the next image is an envelope for correcting the ration queue. At that threshold Shanti Parva ends and the next narrative crisis of Anushasana Parva begins.

Narrative Time, Focalisation, and the Classroom's Many Voices

The external time is concentrated between dawn and evening in Phagun, followed by preparations for the shelter's close of day. Within it coexist Naira's absence, Irfan's former customer, Harish's returned consignment, the night watch, the dampness left by earlier rain, and anticipation of the next ration distribution. Past and future enter the same setting. The original chapter contains no independent ancient storyline from the Ramayana or Mahabharata, although its introductory framing mentioned a dual-temporal intertext. That signal does not take the form of an actual separate ancient scene here. Recurrent objects and the time of memory are the principal techniques.

Focalisation moves from the prick of chalk in Zubaida's foot to the girl's wet notebook, Padma's three languages, Sanket's equipment, Sarita's arrested breathing, Irfan's grease-stained palm, Harish's returned consignment, the elderly woman's pause at the word “consent,” and the child's running flatbread. As a result, the chapter does not remain the solitary story of a head teacher. Neither is the classroom an established elite site where “knowledge-givers” simply dispense knowledge. Children alter the questions, the elderly demand alternatives to written meanings, and craftspeople determine rates for their labour. Several fields of life compose the narrative voice. Although the narrator remains in the third person, the reader is not given one exclusive centre of decision.

Shanti Parva's Conclusion: Achievement, Risk, and a Bridge to the Next Parva

A distinctive artistic achievement is the reactivation of imaginative play and social curiosity after domestic bereavement. The girl's three crooked letters, Sarita's blank sheet, payment for the labour of singing, the elderly woman's demand to understand for herself, and the safe boundaries of the classroom combine as separate small decisions into a full story of institution-building. This victory does not reverse death, eliminate Rukhsana's exhaustion in the kitchen, or instantly abolish earlier inequalities. Its effect lies in the fact that the characters can still ask questions.

A limitation is that too many questions arise at precisely the right time on the classroom's first day, and their answers are also remarkably lucid. Admission, disability, recording, privacy, vendors' costs, payment for folk songs, building safety, oral explanation, and discrepancies in rations all seem to acquire the outline of a solution in a single day. Such planned completeness can diminish the spontaneous disorder of the story. Yet the running flatbread, wet notebook, and Sarita's moments of silence interrupt this mechanical tendency. The motion of Shanti Parva's last sentence is especially meaningful: the classroom has opened, but its first test will come in the coming ration queue. Completing one parva does not mean the end of social conflict; the subject of the next parva emerges naturally from within the story.

Shanti Parva / Uttara Kanda: Overall Narratological Assessment of Chapters 133–144

How the Plot Continues After Mourning

The structure of Shanti Parva's twelve chapters is not simply the establishment of government after war. Chapter 133 raises the question of temporary leadership; Chapters 134–135 follow the Mahabharata-era narrative of Yudhishthira, Bhishma, and Draupadi; Chapter 136 presents Sarita's first testimony; Chapter 137 Aditi's old report; Chapter 138 distinct files of responsibility; Chapter 139 dual-temporal editing between Udayana and Rahina; Chapter 140 the social relations between action and wages; Chapter 141 the parallel currents of help and litigation; Chapter 142 medicine distribution; Chapter 143 collective rules for the shelter; and Chapter 144 the opening of the classroom. This sequence unfolds many layers of institution-building. The central question moves from "Who will govern?" to "How will people's work, names, and stories continue after governance is established?" The independent scenes of the last four chapters are largely modern; their relations to the Ramayana and Mahabharata are structural rather than maintained by inserting separate ancient scenes by force.

The opening chapters contain comparable questions of public assemblies and ancient rajadharma, but the concluding chapters bring new objects to the centre: the iron chest of assistance, boxes of medicine, the shelter's keys, and the girl's notebook. They reveal respectively the relation between the private and the public in assistance, the time of living bodies, institutional succession, and imaginative futures. Through this sequence of objects, the narrative movement of Shanti Parva becomes legitimacy of government → organisation of practice → new curiosity in ordinary life.

Multiple Layers of Time, Focalisation, and Life After Grief

Narrative time includes many present-day scenes from morning to evening, but the parva as a whole is not linear. The ancient scenes of Yudhishthira and Bhishma open the ethical time following the Mahabharata war; the mourning-related pause in Udayana's philosophical debate is edited in parallel with Rahina's modern family conflict; the deaths of Naira and Urmila return through the surviving characters' material memories and silences. The author sets the extended time of work among the living against the earlier concentrated mourning for death. The date of an administrative letter, a labourer's unpaid hours, and the timing of household expenses are not identical experiences of a single present. The story attempts to give voice to their inequalities.

The narrator mostly remains in the third person but does not grant a fixed monopoly over focalisation. Gomati and Rama certainly coordinate the story; nevertheless, Aditi revises her earlier sentence, Rahina seeks independent time for her shop, Mahesh's wife chooses a different room, Vibha insists on the commercial time of profit and wages, Rani specifies limits of safe cleaning, Ruhani relinquishes singular authority, and children and the elderly redirect the questions in Padma and Sanket's classroom. Through such distributed focalisation, the "single name" of the novel's initial death register changes in Shanti Parva into active narrative places for numerous people.

Achievement in Emotion, Language, and Social Polyphony

The emotional ground of the parva is neither uniform karuna rasa nor administrative calm. Grief, hesitation, disagreement, practical endurance, professional pride, and classroom laughter all have a voice. Sarita maintains the private limits of Naira's notebook; Kabir prevents the words of a former adversary from becoming a false confession of crime; Rukhsana counts not only the cost of food but the time of her labour; a small child draws a six-legged flatbread. Emotional force arises from the broken yet continuing lives of the characters. The new classroom does not bring Naira back, yet her absence becomes a source of new opportunities for learning. The language moves away from melodramatic climaxes of grief and enlarges its meaning through small objects and interrupted exchanges.

With these achievements, a critical objection is unavoidable. Rama, Gomati, Salma, Zubaida, Shabnam, Vibha, Meena, and other characters sometimes speak in unusually lucid, similarly structured, miniature theoretical propositions. Differences between institutions, wages, privacy, and rights are often articulated in almost the same rhythm. The distinctive idiom of an individual, village sounds, the inconsistencies of frustration, and sudden social friction can be suppressed under this ordered understanding. Some characters seem to enter simply to explain a new page or a difference in charges. The breadth of characterisation is not, in itself, a virtue: this is a genuine tension between epic scale and narrative depth. These people are remembered most vividly not for documentary distinctions but for physical acts—Rani's sandal, Rahim's pillowcase, Mahesh's daughter's drawing of houses, Ruhani's fear as she gives up the keys, and the child's running flatbread.

Causal Outcomes and the Actual Opening of the Next Parva

By the end of the twelve chapters, several real changes in circumstances have occurred. Gomati takes temporary leadership; Aditi withdraws an earlier conclusion; separate files are created; a hidden waiver condition

emerges from a receipt for assistance; safe medicines continue to be supplied; Rahim's four sacks are released; the shelter's keys pass from one person in charge to an elected representative; and a classroom opens on a safe veranda rather than in a dangerous room. But the final determination of Mahesh's murder, the unidentified third medicine box, Rani's old wages, the shelter's blocked drain, Madhav's dispute, Urmila's unpaid earnings, and errors in the ration register remain. These outstanding matters are not merely a list of unfinished headings; they are the causal threads of the approaching Anushasana Parva.

Shanti Parva's literary achievement is thus not to declare that "order has been established," but to present institutional order as a living process subject to continuing scrutiny and revision. At the end the girl writes her answer herself, while Zubaida records only the date. This modest shift gives the novel's long concern with names, registers, and labour a new form: beyond the question of who has the right to write someone's name lies the question of who can write the answer to their own question. This is the concluding narrative achievement. At the same time an approaching error in ration distribution opens the door to Chapter 145; Shanti Parva reaches its distinctive conclusion without stopping the movement of the novel as a whole.

ANUSHASANA PARVA / UTTARA KANDA

Chapter 145 — The Ration Queue

Opening the Public Narrative Through a Sack's Torn Seam

"The Ration Queue" begins with an apparently minor mishap: at daybreak in Phagun 2040, two handfuls of rice spill from a sack. Rukhsana tries to gather them, while an employee dismisses the loss, saying, "That much does not get entered in the accounts." This opening is not a statistic of scarcity but a choice of scene and focal point. The narrator does not begin at the distributor's table or with an administrative order; the narrative opens upon the bent body of a woman picking up grains of food. Rukhsana's action sets the rice on the floor against the grain recorded on paper. Right at the beginning, she makes three marks: the goods have arrived, the people have arrived, and entitlement remains unfulfilled. Three different outcomes may occupy the same line, but the story's meaning lies in their differences. In Chapter 144, the register of children's learning and the ration register remained distinct; here the distinction moves from a question about schooling into the scene of public distribution.

Separating the clean grains that can be saved into another vessel, and keeping the dusty grains out of distribution, is not merely a matter of hygiene: it begins the moral drama of the object. At the end, those same clean grains are added to the weighed quantity, yet "no miracle brought back the grain of the empty months." This sentence draws a circle between the beginning and the ending, without turning repetition into a complete solution. Grains can be counted again; the hunger of bygone months cannot be restored. The opposition between the recurrence of an object and irretrievable time is a significant narratological achievement of the chapter.

The Sequence of Events: From Correcting Names to Beneficiary Representation

The first conflict concerns Savitri Sardar. After the river changed course, her household was recorded differently in the registers of the old and new villages; even though today's slip carries a corrected name, the space against an earlier distribution date is still empty. The employee who says "The name has been corrected" reaches a narrative endpoint different from the period encompassed by Savitri's question, "What about the month when I came back empty-handed?" Savitri accepts today's grain but records her disagreement with treating the earlier loss as settled. The outcome of the event is precise: the name and village details were corrected; compensation for the earlier loss remained under consideration; and she received a separate application number. The unequal measures of the scene's "success" emerge through the clash of the characters' statements. The narrator need not impose an external ruling.

In Dulari Rajwar's case, a bag of relief supplies is attached to a form waiving a private debt. Dulari's statement—"Remove the wrongful condition, but do not stop distribution"—is not a heroine's proclamation; it is dialogue that changes the immediate direction of events. Rukhsana does not tear up the old document; nor does Gomati take the employee's entire job into her own hands. Under the new interim instruction, a signature acknowledging receipt of grain does not constitute a waiver of private debt; subsequently, the offending clause is removed with a cancellation stamp. Dulari's debt dispute does not end. Preserving the old, erroneous copy has a particular significance in the story's construction: the paper that once trapped a character now preserves a different account of the past. Yet no judicial conclusion may be claimed here; the original narrative shows the characters' conduct in the present.

Rehana's aching leg and Anwari's presence carry the scene from the public queue into the private time of medical treatment. To prevent treatment from being interrupted by a discrepancy of one digit, Salma places the

essential distribution marker on the public sheet and the medical particulars in a private envelope. Temporary approval and the date for a subsequent review are obtained; a permanent correction to the name and numerical entry is not. In this subplot, the physical time of the queue—the line, the sun, the officer's telephone—collides with the time of the child's next dose of medicine. Narrative tension arises not from melodramatic claims of tragedy but from the everyday consequences of this distinction.

By midday, Rukhsana can no longer record every objection herself. The story therefore moves from outside the distribution room to a small meeting of beneficiaries. How to hear people who have travelled from far away, families with incomplete identification, and beneficiaries who cannot be present becomes the subject of debate. Eventually Savitri is elected principal representative and Dulari deputy representative; the office liaison continues to manage the supply. Savitri accepts the limitation that she must not decide her own previous compensation claim. This is the chapter's principal turn in character development: at the beginning Savitri recounts an injustice she has experienced; at the end she assumes a position in which she must listen to the experiences of others. Her name has moved from a corrected list into a new public role, but that role does not erase her personal loss.

Time and Place, Narrator, and Social Polyphony

The chapter's present is confined to a single day in Phagun, from dawn to dusk. Into this one day enter cooking labour from Pus and Magh, rations missing in earlier months, an old change in the river's course, Rehana's injury, a forthcoming medical appointment, and the question of the nomadic people's next journey. The third-person narrator keeps the geography of the present scene distinct: the table, the tamarind tree, the veranda, the rear of the queue, the small meeting, and the storeroom door. Although the story consists of almost uninterrupted scenes of dialogue, brief indications of the sun rising and softening intermittently vary the pace. Past refusals occasionally return in the form of slips of paper; there is no independent, extended flashback scene.

The distribution of narrative voices is deliberate here, but meaningful. Savitri's measured demand, Dulari's ironic question about the large form, Salma's short medical statements, Padma's explanation to a child, an elderly person's demand to have the weighing done in front of them, and a nomadic man's difficulty over travel introduce distinct social experiences. A child's question—"If the wrong letter is written in two places, must it be corrected twice?"—simplifies much of the argument about paperwork. Yet the child is not merely a vehicle for the author's lesson: the child recognizes a concealed classification through the everyday experience of learning. An elderly person counts and checks their bag personally;

receiving assistance does not end their independent agency. Rukhsana's hesitation over entering her own working hours reveals at once the value she places on public service and her reluctance to make her labour visible.

Achievement and Artistic Limit: The Road Opened at the End of the Queue

The chapter's achievement lies in preventing "ration" from retaining a single meaning: the weight of grain, hunger in past months, private debt, medical documents, elderly people's access, representation, and the labour of distribution all develop as layers around an actual queue. The three marks, torn sack, empty distribution entry, cancellation stamp, and register of exceptions become interconnected narrative signs. But the artistic risk is equally clear. Nearly every character delivers an exceptionally lucid statement of principle at the most convenient moment; the employee repeatedly proposes a false conclusion, and a character supplies the exact distinction needed to correct it. Ordinary social hesitation, the recurrent confusion of disputes, and the inarticulate responses of tired bodies are suppressed in places. The issue of not allowing absent beneficiaries to vote also receives a rather easy resolution. Here the reformist purpose of the narrative diminishes the unpredictability of the scene.

Nevertheless, at the end the nomadic man folds his old pass, puts it into his pocket, and asks the way to Fakira. This small action provides a direct causal bridge to Chapter 146. Despite Savitri and Dulari's election, he has not received an answer to his questions of travel and livelihood. Thus the opening chapter of Anushasana Parva ends not with a proclamation of victory, but with a new character whose path forward remains blocked.

Chapter 146 — Fakira's Pass

The Window Grille, the Yellow Slip, and a Morning Brought to a Halt

"Fakira's Pass" opens with a trembling yellow slip at the ticket window of a railway junction. As with the torn sack in the preceding chapter, a small object opens the entire story; but the change of scene extends the issue from receiving grain to the time required for movement and the time in which earnings are lost. Fakira is alive, yet the death marker remains in an old travel register. The contrast between the character's living body and the red letters on a computer screen produces a sharp irony at the opening. The employee cannot alter the master register independently; Fakira has a copy acknowledging the correction, but no explicit order authorizing an immediate travel pass. The first outcome is not that the office has

recognized a living person, but that a living person is once more trapped inside an old document.

Fakira keeps a weighing plate, a knife for untying knots, an account book for charges, and a copy of his amended testimony separately in his shoulder bag. The arrangement of these objects brings his multiple roles before the reader in one scene: he is a porter, a worker, a witness to an earlier episode of violence, and a traveller obstructed by a false entry of death. The narrator does not compress these lives into a single documentary identity. After missing the morning train, Fakira writes in his ledger, "Payment for the first consignment not received." The movement from an event marker to damage to a livelihood is extraordinarily concrete. Here time is not merely the clock: it is an opportunity to sell and to work.

Interconnected Subplots and the Day's Chain of Decisions

The nomadic family arrives here from the exceptions list in the ration queue. Savitri and Dulari come as newly elected representatives; their concern is not merely to repeat the case of correcting Fakira's name, but to prevent a person's future from disappearing between offices. With Rama Karna's entry, the narrative expands into a more elaborate administrative setting. Fakira's earlier testimony said that he heard two blows of iron, not that he saw anyone breaking a gate. He refuses to let that limited statement become a condition of his travel identity. Rama says that an irrelevant private statement must not be added to the travel file. The narrative consequence is that a reader who earlier approached Fakira as an instrument of investigation now encounters him in the separate hours of his own life. The mystery of the earlier metallic sounds is not solved, yet the travel-pass decision moves ahead.

The second strand concerns Nandu Nat, Maina, and Jhilmil. A fairground proposal requires children to attend throughout the night and offers reduced remuneration in the name of "public interest." Jhilmil chooses time for her studies; Nandu sets down the costs and refuses to make his daughter a means of saving the fee of an adult performer. At the end, a revised proposal specifies a small stage, a two-hour performance, and clear payment for adult artists. The organiser's original condition is removed, but compensation for the old, broken stage remains separate. The small-stage strand is directly connected to Fakira's restored ability to travel: after receiving his pass, Fakira agrees to transport Nandu's equipment safely at a fair rate. The correction of one error in the papers opens a new possibility for action in another character's life. Such causality is one of the chapter's strengths of construction.

The third strand concerns Farid Chik. Its aim is to divide time between the family's morning trade and Farid's evening classes. A school clerk has

treated his approved evening attendance arrangement as an ordinary absence and added an extra fee; the error is corrected in the new admission arrangement. Farid receives a receipt for the prescribed fee and agrees with his father upon a limited share of the morning work. "The fee has been corrected" does not mean that all his schooling is now free; nor has the family's former debt been transferred in full to Farid's name. Through this subplot, dialogue between father and son creates dramatic tension among affection, the family's financial burden, and new literacy. The resolve "Never hand it over without reading it" echoes the opening hesitation about signing, now in the next generation.

Narrative Time, Dual Identity, and Focalisation

The present-day story advances within a single day from the missed train at dawn to the tea stall and the school veranda in the evening. Along the way, the earlier hospital testimony, Fakira's many names, Nandu's former performance, Farid's debt, and the previous day's ration queue return in brief anticipatory and retrospective references. Temporal markers—the train's departure, an hour-long computer check, the first new consignment, and the evening school session—bind the scenes into one geography. Unlike the recurring river-and-boat narrative associated with Guha's riverbank in Chapter 26, the railway junction is the principal chronotope here: railway schedules, the ticket window, the fair, and the classroom clock measure the characters' mobility.

"Sai Fakir" and "Diwan Madar" are two entries in Fakira's registers; he gives his own name as "Fakira." The narrator does not turn this variety of names into a single mystery about the "correct name." Instead, the story listens to how far a person wants his identity to be constituted by his own labour and life. Nor is a nomadic family's inability to provide a permanent address presented as proof of falsehood; it is an experience arising from a genuinely mobile life. That family is given time to submit an application for renewal, not an immediate pass. This open difference prevents the narrative from declaring Fakira's successful restoration of travel rights a collective victory for every itinerant family.

Emotional Progression, Narrative Limit, and the Next Classroom

The chapter's emotional movement begins with irony, passes through anger, economic loss, and cautious hope, and finally reaches a limited satisfaction. At the end, Fakira tells the tea seller's son that the mystery of the old sound remains unresolved, but the travel pass has been issued. The reader understands that one thread of the investigation has deliberately been left undecided. This choice makes the character an independent person rather than a merely useful witness. Fakira reads out the particulars of the new card and records "pass received" separately from "claim for lost

earnings pending." The plot achieves the restoration of one activity of life, not the settlement of the whole past.

There is also a limitation. Fakira, Nandu, Farid, Rama, and the nomadic family all speak in unusually clear statements that classify their respective claims; by the end of the day many processes have acquired orderly copies, dates, and separate compartments for claims. Such symmetrical discipline can make the unfinished disorder of a living world seem somewhat diminished. Nonetheless, Jhilmil tying her shoelaces, Fakira's drinking glass, Maina stitching a book, and the light laughter between Farid and his father lend the warmth of domestic uncertainty to this structure. In the final school scene, Sanket designs different ways of giving an answer. Through this single transition in narrative craft, Chapter 147 raises its new question: after the right to move, what might a scene of the right to answer in one's own way look like?

Chapter 147 — Sanket's Classroom

The Half-Opened Board: A Device Questions Its Own Maker

"Sanket's Classroom" opens with Sanket attaching three colours of cloth, raised threads, large letters, and small wooden symbols to a strip of bamboo. The opening introduces a rhythm entirely different from the railway junction of the previous chapter. At the ticket window, a person was halted by the official account of his identity; here the maker of a device is halted by his own decisions. Sanket has designated red as the signal for "Help needed," but Padma asks, "You have thought about it. Did you ask the children?" For a moment, the half-opened board becomes the moral and narrative centre of the classroom. Ordinarily a device is first made and then put to use; here its users redefine its meaning during the process of making it. The character's development begins in this small reversal.

Meera Mandal draws attention to the different circumstances of children who can touch a thread but cannot see its colour, who cannot touch the thread, and who have only begun learning to read. A girl taps the table twice, softly. Padma accepts it as an answer. This humorous return of the initial "two taps" occurs in passage 23, when the yellow window of the portable board jams and Jhilmil signals to Sanket that he needs help in precisely this fashion. The recurrence of an object or gesture is not mere ornament: the first time the girl's sign represents an unfamiliar language of human communication; the second time it has become a shared language for identifying a teacher's error. Sanket is embarrassed at first and then laughs. His change of character is made visible not through a

manifesto, but through the moment when he can laugh at the incompleteness of his own device.

Admission, Language, and Recording: The Classroom's Polycentric Events

The admission of a boy from an itinerant family and his sister is an important early turning point. The girl's name is correct in the temporary class register, but she has no permanent address. Meera and Padma preserve the available school record, a mobile means of contact, and a date for the next verification, while allowing her to attend class that very day. At the end, an explicit order reads, "Address verification pending," and directs that this shall not exclude her from the classroom. The subplot's achievement is actual access to education, not an invented permanent address or a complete correction of the register. The change is small compared with other incidents in the chapter, yet exceptionally effective as an event: the scene of the girl recognising the letters of her name turns the initial social difficulty into an act performed by a child's hand.

In the mother-tongue class, Rachna Dhimal invites the children to speak the many words they use for "home." Although a single word stands on the classroom board, the children attach meanings drawn from their different experiences. Sanket asks whether all the words can fit onto his board. Rachna answers, "Not every word will fit on the board, but the right to hear everyone's word can fit." The narrative importance of this exchange is not that someone has announced a principle; more importantly, a teacher's ready-made device encounters a community and discovers its limitations. Although payment for a full five-child class remains unresolved, some of the teaching hours are approved. Linguistic plurality is therefore not confined to poetic celebration: the daily hours of the teacher who sustains it become visible within the story.

A local organisation proposes filming the children's hand signs for public publicity. Sanket initially raises the camera, then stops when he sees the permission form's blanket clause granting "all rights." Padma's declaration that "a face is not the property of a group" has consequences for the arrangement of the classroom scene: options are prepared for shared learning material, receipts for expenses, and presentations without identifying features, while permission to show the faces of children or shelter residents is kept separate. An amended letter from the organisation arrives at the end, but Padma does not sign immediately. This open decision denies the audience the comforting ending in which "everyone has agreed." Sanket's statement, "I made the board with my hands, but the voices of those who practise on it belong to them," traces his journey from ownership of a device toward an understanding of reciprocal dialogue.

Parallel Times: Transport, Domestic Care, and a Classroom Test

The chapter extends from morning to evening at school, but numerous strands of time unfold within that single day. Madan Raut has a demand upon the same vehicle for a school run and for a possible hour of patient transport. A plan for a safe alternative vehicle is prepared, while payment for an earlier diversion remains outstanding. Structurally, this incident links the movement of education to the account of the hospital crisis. The reader has already encountered the rescue of patients in Sauptika Parva; through that memory, a vehicle schedule ceases to be an ordinary school-bus problem. Yet the new difficulty is not turned into another spectacular collapse: the memory of a previous event acts upon planning in the present.

Devi Gond refuses a request to "testify" about her hospital trauma and instead chooses to teach people how to use the health-sign card. The narrator places three different experiences within a single sequence: her head injury, her responsibility for giving medicine to her mother, and the hours needed for training. Following a sharp telephone conversation with her brother, an immediate arrangement for sharing domestic care is made, not a settlement of the entire future. Devi does not miss the training, and Sanket's health card does not replace medical diagnosis. This incident offers an opportunity to deepen embodied memory: the hospital accident now returns in the language of recollection, but the character refuses to let her present role be confined to the old event.

The account of Meera Mandal's unpaid work as an assistant teacher in an earlier mobile classroom enters toward the close of the day. Payment is recommended for the period clearly documented in writing; testimony and reports are sought for the remainder. Alongside it, Rachna's remaining teaching hours, Madan's former transport charges, and the value of Sanket's labour in making the device remain undecided. The story enters four achievements of educational reform and four outstanding questions in the same decision register. Children's freedom to attend school must not rest upon the economic invisibility of teachers: this is the common thread connecting the subplots.

Layers of Narrative Voice, a Pause for Laughter, and Critical Appraisal

The third-person narrator places Sanket and Padma at the centre, but focalisation shifts among notebooks, hands, voices, mother tongues, wounded bodies, and children's questions. In this distributed focalisation the teacher is not solely a source of knowledge: he learns the meaning of his own device from the children. The old question paper's instruction, "Look at the picture and write its name," gives way to a daily assessment distinguishing the comprehension of meaning, the medium of

communication, and the need for further practice. The change does not appear before the reader as a dramatic victory; it becomes a set of varied scenes of classroom exercise. The original text does not say that the district's formal annual examination will accept precisely this arrangement.

Artistically, the chapter's principal achievement is the return of laughter to a society living after grief. The children's collective laughter at Sanket's jammed device neither erases the hospital accident nor pays the unpaid wages, but it introduces a fresh rhythm into the classroom. The weakness, however, is that linguistic diversity, admissions, filming, transport, health cards, domestic care, wages, assessment, and grants are all settled or deferred with extraordinary orderliness in a single day. At times the dialogue becomes as exact as a training manual. The failure of Sanket's device and the girl's unexpected taps offer the most vivid counterpoint to this planned rhythm. At the end Jhilmil asks about examinations and fees. Once the evaluation of understanding has been raised, the value of educational labour becomes the natural narrative necessity of the next chapter, 148.

Chapter 148 — Padma's Fee

Three Ledgers: The Story Between Zero Tuition and Invisible Labour

The opening scene of "Padma's Fee" reveals three ledgers: enrolment, teachers' hours, and an empty column for fees. For a moment the reader expects a demand for payment to oppose children's free admission, but Padma begins by writing, "Nothing from the pupil in the name of admission." The ensuing question and the conflict of the narrative concern the invisible hours teachers spend mediating among languages, meeting guardians, and explaining consent forms. In this sense, the title deliberately generates a double expectation: the "fee" is not a teacher's supposed private collection but the process through which the labour used by an institution acquires a visible value. The smell of cumin coming from Rukhsana's kitchen connects the school accounts room to a world of living work.

The clerk mentions Padma's earlier voluntary assistance; Padma sets down the hours freely donated and the duties assigned by the institution on separate sheets. Their opening exchange reiterates the central tension: making labour invisible by calling it "help." The novel, however, does not advance one universal solution and end immediately. Characters from different families and occupations test the argument through distinct scenes. At first the three ledgers are small accounting symbols; at the end,

their filled, partly filled, and still empty spaces return. The structural circle is completed, but decisive economic justice is not achieved.

Occupation, Language, and Generational Choice: Four Character Strands

Saraswati Thakur wants to enrol her daughter in training in electrical equipment. The loss of earnings from turning away morning customers, sharing work with her sister-in-law, and pressure to write "family occupation" on the form constitute the incident's three stages. Her daughter says clearly that she wants to learn the safety of wires, not her mother's scissors. The form is submitted, part of the fee is paid against a receipt, and the entrance test is due the following week; final admission to the training course has not been granted. Within the novel's broad social design of 157 occupational communities, this event opens the tension between occupational continuity and a new generation's independent choice. The value of Saraswati's work does not disappear from view: when the mother takes time off to accompany her daughter, the cost of those hours is entered in the household accounts. Padma asks that the cost of explaining the form come not from the family but from the institution's designated assistance budget. The narrative thus stages the question of preventing one stream of labour from becoming a burden on another.

Hari Natuwa's performance proposal introduces a cultural timescale distinct from the school-fee dispute. A larger fee is offered on the condition that he ridicule his own caste, occupation, and speech and perform a scene in which a child is falsely humiliated. Hari refuses this language; his son Anshu hopes that the extra money might pay for his books. Their conversation is not simply an exchange of slogans: the boy genuinely worries about the household's expenses, and the father acknowledges the cost of foregoing possible income. Later a smaller performance goes ahead, the audience laughs without the degrading scene, and part of the advance pays for Anshu's books and some travel costs, though not his entire education. The simultaneous moments of Hari's final drumbeat and Anshu closing his book create a visible synchrony between working time and learning time. It is among the chapter's most successful small scenes.

Nasima Shershahbadi enrols her daughter in school while continuing her work stitching the bindings of books, and asks to join an adult-education class herself. The daughter is mocked for the language spoken at home; the incident is recorded, but the young person accused is not conclusively condemned without first being heard. A scene in which the correct pronunciation of the letters of a name is learned turns an abstract debate about language rights into the bodily act of speaking. Nasima's receipt for

binding books preserves the separate remuneration due for her work. Her daughter is permitted to continue sitting in the classroom; a final correction to the old record remains pending. The simultaneous education of mother and daughter—the mother in adult study, the daughter in modern schooling—extends the work's intergenerational arc of literacy.

The question of separate rights over Sanket's board and the pupils' voices recurs. A local group proposes selling material that includes recordings of the students' voices, and Sanket refuses. In class one girl answers by drawing, while the accounts sheet records a zero beside written letters. Padma keeps the comprehension of meaning separate from practice in forming letters. This episode connects directly to Chapter 147: the alternative language of response enabled by Sanket's device now becomes an issue of teachers' assessment hours and the real labour of constructing the device. In this way, the chapter's title, "Fee," becomes not merely a discussion of receiving money but a narrative reckoning of the human hours on which the exchange of knowledge depends.

The Weaving of Narrative Time and the Chapter's Ethical Polyphony

The chapter runs from the three ledgers at dawn through midday travel and Hari's evening performance to Padma's final accounts at night. References to the past enter the present through Jhilmil's question the day before, Saraswati's former earnings, Nasima's transfer certificate, Hari's earlier proposal, and the assistant teacher's unpaid wages. The narrative presents the social times of many characters simultaneously within a single day. A long scene of Padma's argument occupies the midday meeting; between its passages, smaller private scenes of household earnings, the drum, a torn book, a daughter making a radio measurement, and medical instructions alter the pace. There is no independent ancient scene from the Ramayana or Mahabharata here, although the long aftermath associated with Uttara Kanda remains the structural background of the entire Anushasana Parva.

The narrator's gaze is distributed from Padma's table to Saraswati's bag, Hari's stage, Nasima's needle, Sanket's board, Zubaida's shelter, and Rukhsana's kitchen receipt. In this polycentric structure, one person's problem is not absorbed into another person's fee. Medical instructions are explained in a private room, and an unclear dosage is referred back to a physician. Linguistic mediation and clinical decision-making remain distinct, but the narration pays particular attention to the privacy experienced by the family receiving care. The family asks, "Do we have to pay money now?" Zubaida's answer ends a brief interval of fearful uncertainty. A change in language produces a small but actual change in the course of a character's life.

Partial Decisions, the Risk of Repetition, and Janki's Open Copy

The school committee accepts five rules: identifying the work performed, verifying hours, budgeting by institution, setting limits on disclosure, and approving voluntary work separately. A limited honorarium is approved for a trial period; the financial decision on the full proposal is outstanding. Meera's old wages, Madan's earlier journeys, and Rachna's remaining teaching hours remain separate unresolved matters. The real narrative outcome of Padma's fee is therefore not full payment, but partial recognition of invisible time and a place for it in the public accounts. Saraswati's daughter has yet to receive a decision on her training admission; Hari's revised contract does not meet every expense of his household. Amid many incompletions, the narrative remains bounded by this specific decision.

One weakness is that many subplots share the same design: a mistaken or ungenerous proposal arrives, a character states the limits of their labour or identity, an amended document is prepared, and the remaining claim is kept separate. The repetition gives the work an orderly rhythm, but increases the risk that the distinct consciousness of a character will be converted into the language of organised social theory. In particular, the systematic presence of so many occupational communities and institutional questions on one school day exposes the composition's planned outline. Hari's stage humour, Nasima putting her needle away safely, Saraswati's daughter making a radio measurement, and the smell from Rukhsana's kitchen lend experiential depth to this limitation.

In the final two passages, a surviving copy of an old, false accusation of child theft appears on a noticeboard, and Janki again demands a public correction. Padma does not immediately tear up the paper and pronounce someone guilty; Janki insists on a space for her own statement. The last page of the three ledgers is filled, but Janki's copy lies open on one side of the table. This open ending causally generates Chapter 149, "Janki's Rebuttal." The account of fees ends not with completeness but with the still audible voice of an old public humiliation.

Anushasana Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 145–148

From Grain to Voice, from Travel to Lessons, from Lessons to the Value of Labour

The sequence of the four chapters forms a clear but layered narrative arc. Savitri and Dulari become representatives in the ration queue; at its end a nomadic man asks the way to Fakira's pass; once Fakira's travel pass is

restored, a consignment of Nandu's equipment can move; his daughter Jhilmil attends school; in Sanket's classroom the children determine their own means of responding; and Padma then raises the question of the value of the linguistic and teaching labour required to keep that classroom functioning. In this sequence, "paper" is not merely an object but a means of changing the reader's expectations. Each ending points not to a lesson about a new category of rights, but to the concrete necessity of the next scene.

A grain of rice in the first chapter, a yellow travel slip in the second, a portable tactile board in the third, and three ledgers in the fourth establish an ascending sequence of narrative objects. The grain is bodily hunger itself; the travel slip is access to the time of earning a living; the board offers an alternative medium of expression; the ledgers reckon concretely with the labour that makes these possibilities real. In this sequence of objects, the new discipline becomes not a narrative of "one kind of rule for everyone," but one of refusing to erase distinct rhythms of life by imposing one upon another. This idea is produced through the recurrence of objects, not only through the narrator's final conclusion.

Multiple Layers of Time and Characters' Agency

The external time of all four chapters is the continuous life of mornings and evenings in Phagun 2040. Yet past months without rations, Fakira's missed train, Jhilmil's next school morning, Devi's training day, Saraswati's daughter's coming examination, and Nasima's evening adult class bring divergent pasts and futures into the same present. Analepsis generally arises through the small action of someone reading an old document, rather than an extended independent scene set in the past. None of these four chapters has a separate ancient epic scene; the intertextual relationship with Uttara Kanda operates at the level of long postwar reconstruction and responsibility toward the living. A potential allusion should not thereby be mistaken for an event actually narrated.

Focalisation is distributed among Rukhsana's floor, Savitri's blank distribution entry, Fakira's ledger, Jhilmil's shoelace, the accounts kept by Farid and his father, Sanket's jammed device, Devi's injured body, Saraswati's scissors, and Nasima's needle. Through these precise choices of scene, the reader encounters the language of rights within particular bodies and households. Gomati, Padma, Rama, and Rukhsana are comparatively important coordinators, but decisive choices are made by Savitri, Dulari, Fakira, the children, Nandu, Devi, and Nasima themselves. The limits of polyphony emerge when many characters speak in similarly lucid, classificatory sentences; the child's question in the queue, Jhilmil's laughter, and Farid's father's hesitation introduce differences within this uniformity.

Emotional Achievement, Creative Objection, and the Next Episode

After the grief of Stri Parva and the institutional renewal of Shanti Parva, the first four chapters of Anushasana Parva extend the narrative's emotional range into everyday life: hunger, fear of lost work, a child's laughter, intimacy with one's language, pride in an occupation, and the value of teaching labour. The anticipated dramatic climax is not always firmly plotted; a small alteration to an account book, a corrected date, or a decision about safe practice constitutes the chapter's outcome. In this slower narrative order, the early tragedy of the dead and the living is dispersed into numerous small possibilities of social relationship.

But this very craft entails a real danger of almost uniform repetition in the event pattern: identify an error, specify a boundary, create a separate list, and leave an unresolved claim. In places this discipline reduces the spontaneous disorder of the story, the diversity of local speech, and the characters' unspoken resistance. Consequently, when enumerating these chapters' achievements, the clarity of rules alone must not be taken as a sufficient measure of artistic significance. The literary effect is strongest where the plan of the story is disrupted: grain spilling onto the floor, a morning train missed, the board's window jamming, Hari's drum and Anshu's book closing at the same moment.

At the end of Chapter 148, the old copy of an accusation in Janki's hand turns the story once more toward an unfinished history of public humiliation. The review cannot therefore declare Anushasana Parva complete at this point. Chapter 149 must show how the earlier event of a public rebuttal returns in the reader's newly formed memory.

Chapter 149 — Janki's Rebuttal

Uncracked Glass, Yellowing Paper: Public Memory at a Standstill

"Janki's Rebuttal" opens at the glass covering an old school noticeboard. The glass is uncracked, but the accusation posted behind it has yellowed with damp. Two kinds of material time coexist in the image: the glass remains whole and the paper is ageing, yet its power to humiliate continues to operate in the present. The open sheet at the close of Chapter 148 now becomes the central narrative object. The author does not close the matter by calling an earlier public correction a "solution"; whether the corrected information has actually reached every part of the school becomes the cause of the next sequence of events. In the morning two guardians pull their children away from Janki. The story's first genuine disruption is thus not a new accusation but the continuing social effect of old words.

Janki stands with the unfinished border of a woven mat, a receipt for market charges, and a folded copy of the rebuttal in her bag. These three objects disclose three different positions held by this woman in society: craftswoman, sufferer of commercial loss, and person demanding the public rewriting of her humiliation. The narrator does not begin the rebuttal with a heroic speech at a meeting but with Asad's key, the opening of the glass case, copies of the notice, and the delay in circulating the correction. Making administrative inertia visible in this way accords with the rhythm of Anushasana Parva. Janki's anger does not automatically dissipate within that rhythm: when an old, edited video returns on her phone, a "cold exhaustion" descends into her body. The yellowing paper at the beginning and the bright screen at the end offer two opposed material forms of the same old humiliation.

Circulating the Correction, Rajo's Two Addresses, and Lata's Missing Child: A Polycentric Episode

The chapter's first arc is formed by the exchange among Janki, Asad, and the school. Asad accepts responsibility for his official part in the first unverified notice, but does not claim authorship of words later added by an unknown person. Janki wants the language of the public correction to be as extensive as the circulation of the error through school channels. The narrative distinction here is that an opposing character is not fixed permanently in the position of perpetrator: Asad was initially the employee responsible for an omission, but now actively assists with the correction. The three places at which it is circulated—the school board, the market's notice point, and the bus-stand entrance—extend the action across different sites of public memory. The correction is nonetheless not unlimited: no school order can stop every private mobile-phone circulation. The distance between "posting a notice" and "people reading and accepting it" sustains the reader's tension.

Rajo Bhogta's subplot prevents this section from becoming an exclusively personal account of restoring Janki's standing. Rajo's daughter is not two households, but one person moving between an ancestral connection to the village and a present rented address in town. A repeated digit in a file produces the mistaken appearance of "two names," which reaches the child's classroom and becomes a classmate's question. A clerical error therefore ceases to be a purely bureaucratic affair and affects the child's sense of herself. Rajo sits with her daughter and explains their life in two places, and the child reopens her notebook. This small visual outcome makes the conversation's meaning visible as bodily action. Rajo's two days of transport labour and her daughter's educational assistance become separate cases; a wage order is issued, while receipt of cash remains an event

for a later time. This precise deferral avoids the artificial simplicity of total resolution.

Lata's arrival maintains the painful difference between the original false allegation of child theft and Mithun's actual disappearance. She sits beside Janki but does not authorise the opening of her son's private file in the public meeting. She resists having her grief used as publicity material for someone else's rebuttal. The distinct protection narrative of Chameli and Gunja is not absorbed into the search for Mithun either. Several subplots meet in the shared veranda of one town, but the narrator keeps each one's time and incomplete outcome separate. Within this polycentric construction, Janki's rebuttal is only a temporary confluence of the town's other unfinished stories.

Statement, Reply, and the Mat's Knot: Narrative Time and a Character's Choice

The chapter's external time runs from morning until before nightfall. Within it, three weeks of lost market trade, an earlier notice of correction, anonymous digital editing, Rajo's former village home, and the ongoing search for Mithun enter as brief retrospections. These are not long flashback episodes; they reactivate the past when an old object is read in the present. The sequence moves from the school veranda to the market committee, an open meeting, a staircase, and a railway bridge. Janki does not alter the conditions of her statement in each location; she changes the place in which the words are used. She refuses a sweeping declaration that she is "entirely innocent" because she seeks the withdrawal of a specific charge, not a moral certificate for all time. In this response she becomes more than an innocent victim: she is an active editor of public language.

A conversation between Sarayu and her granddaughter takes the chapter's emotional weight beyond account books and receipts. The granddaughter asks whether anyone will ever call them thieves again. Sarayu does not promise a future forever free of stain; she speaks of written corrections, fair payment for work, and a place where questions can be asked. A hard social circumstance becomes concentrated in a child's short question about the future. The action of untying and retightening a knot in a mat gives the scene a deeper meaning than its spoken conclusion. The threads are being joined, but traces of the old unravelling remain. In the final telephone episode Janki does not immediately post a retaliatory message; she preserves the time of the latest circulation and sends a link to the corrected official letter. What chiefly develops is not dramatic victory but the protagonist's control over the timing of her response to attack.

Achievement, Internal Criticism, and the Next Face

The chapter's major achievement is to remove the false-accusation story from the simple opposition of "truth versus falsehood" and organise it as a sequence of questions: who spoke, who heard, how far the correction travelled, and what it did to people's lives. Asad's partial responsibility, Mahato's printing, Sarayu's actual loss of sales, Janki's undisputed advance refund, and the scheduled assistance for Rajo's books are separate narrative outcomes moving at different speeds, not one declaration of victory. There remains a considerable artistic risk: almost every character explains the limits of their rights in polished, legally precise sentences. Asad, Janki, Padma, and Rajo can sometimes seem to speak in a single voice of "correct classification." The consolidation of so many correction forms within one school day also gives an impression of contrived coincidence. Sarayu's trembling mat, Rajo's daughter closing and reopening her notebook, and the weariness in Janki's body mitigate this risk somewhat.

At the end, the edited video returns again: a correction on the noticeboard and an allegation on the phone coexist. The pairing supplies a natural causal link to the next chapter, "Face and Evidence." As soon as one event ends a fresh question arises: how are people now manufacturing the recognition of faces? Rather than staging the "final rebuttal" of Janki's life, the story opens a new test of the art of making an image.

Chapter 150 — Face and Evidence

Two Phones on a Table: Narrative Beginnings in Visual Distrust

"Face and Evidence" turns the digital recurrence at the end of the preceding chapter into the dawn of its first sentence: in a single night the edited video has returned three times under different names. These repetitions are not three separate accusations concerning three events; they are three circulations of the same image under new captions. The story reads this distinction as an instability of meaning in an age of visual editing. On Sajid Nat's table lie two phones and a paper envelope; the face of a child will not be shown to the public crowd. The "face" in the chapter's title is a compelling visual subject, yet the author chooses from the outset not to display it. The contradiction restructures the reader's expectations: attention shifts from what can be seen to the narrative relationship created by what has been cut and edited into view.

Mohan Kanjar arrives carrying a small wheel detached from his handcart. His work has fallen by half for six days; a customer told him not to bring the cart near children. Mohan's trembling hands and the wheel placed at the edge of the table make visible the social cost of the allegation, preventing the matter from becoming an abstract argument about

matching faces. Sarayu, Janki, and Mohan respond differently, giving the scene a plurality of voices. Janki asks those present what they actually witnessed, Mohan demonstrates the ordinary construction of his cart, and Sarayu silently conveys how old this suspicion is. The committee scene inside the school is thus entered through the language of fear outside it.

The "Original Rehearsal" and the "Edited Copy": How a Scene Is Made Within a Story

The chapter's first important internal narrative is the recording of Sajid's theatrical rehearsal. The committee watches the original scene before a limited group of members: the stage set, a wooden imitation handcart, the actors changing roles, and the shadow retained in the edited version produce very different experiences. Here the making of a moving image becomes the subject of narration itself. The particular effect is that the reader encounters the episode of Janki's rebuttal again in another medium; a "scene" embedded in the narrative changes meaning when detached from its first context. Sajid does not, however, claim that every newly circulating copy derives from the same original file. This restricted statement allows the spread of allegations to continue within the plot; every mystery is not instantly solved.

Mohan's repair slips document three separate jobs from the past. Their sequence restores his working time as something entitled to its own narrative. One customer states explicitly that he suspended an order after seeing the rumour; another had already been in financial difficulty. The distinction between these two causes is narratively significant: rather than turn Mohan into an entirely blameless emblem, it marks the limits between loss that is established and loss that is uncertain. A market committee proposes a declaration of complete innocence in the name of caste; Janki and Mohan demand withdrawal of the specific allegation. Through this formulation, the narrative descends from the collective insult attached to a social category to an individual's work, place, date, and relationships.

Reva, Jatan, and Birsi Enter: From Identity to the Future of Reading

The chapter's second major arc belongs to Reva Gulgulia and her children, Jatan and Birsi. Their previous admission was deferred because no permanent house number could be given. Admission is now accepted on the basis of a current contact location, attendance at a mobile school, and the guardian's consent. The dramatic climax is not simply a signature; Jatan cannot smile until the admission slip is actually in his hand. A gap of time separates the official paper from a child's trust, and the author makes it visible through one small physical act. Reva is asked again how Birsi's name is pronounced. The correct sound of a name, the journey of an

itinerant life, and a fixed school bench move closer together, but the family's mobility is not abolished.

Reva asks about wages lost on working days and money spent having photographs taken; permission to enrol does not compensate for losses from earlier journeys. This unresolved question prevents the account of rights from becoming a mere administrative success: the economic duration of the character's life remains. Meanwhile, a guardian raises a suspicion about the presence of nomadic children. Lata, rising out of her grief for Mithun, opposes making an entire family collectively guilty. This is an important development in her character: the search for her son is unfinished, but she will not endorse an unproven accusation in grief's name. The reader now sees her not only as a mother awaiting a missing child but as a person attentive to another child's right of admission.

News of Keshari Bin's boat forms a third, shorter strand. The boat has not yet been launched for its preliminary trial; the old slip for the timber bears the name "Baluaha," but words on a slip cannot serve as a permanent map of the river. As a new reader, Birsi asks about the word; Jatan draws two lines for their camp and the school but leaves the meeting point between them blank. That empty space is a powerful image in the chapter: admission has been granted, but the entire geography of safe movement remains incomplete. The line becomes a shared symbolic space between the achievement of educational entry and the unresolved question of the waterway.

Narrative Time, the Narrator's Distance, and the Final Question

The temporal sequence stretches from the video recirculated at night to the morning committee, midday admission, and an evening correction notice. Short analepses include the earlier theatre rehearsal, the memory of Naira, Mohan's lost work, Reva's previous application, and the boat's former transport work. The third-person narrator does not confine events to a single person's consciousness, but approaches in turn the experiences of Meera, Mohan, Sajid, Reva, Jatan, Lata, and Janki. They do not all receive equal emotional development: Mohan's trembling hands, Jatan's delayed smile, and Lata's closed notebook are comparatively dense scenes; the committee's final draft is more summary-like.

At the close Jatan asks who may learn to read and which people were once prevented from doing so. This question directly sets in motion the next chapter, "Shambuka's Lesson." The story moves from group humiliation through admission to education, and now creates a new stage for the history of the right to knowledge. From the opening resemblance of faces to the listener's right to question, the novel makes a dramatic turn. A face

may look the same in everyone's eyes, but nothing guarantees that all the children within a classroom will ask the same question.

An artistic objection is that the procedure of public rebuttal and the language of "limited statements" are repeated in nearly the same form from Chapters 149 to 150. The formation of another committee, separate sheets for every claim, classifying a customer's conduct under two causes, and restricting what a boat's slip can prove all risk becoming an overly orderly lesson in social administration. But Mohan reattaching the wheel to his cart, the slips in Reva's children's hands, and Jatan's unanswered question transform critical instruction into living narrative action. In particular, the last question written in large letters is the thematic seed of the rereading of Shambuka.

Chapter 151 — Shambuka's Lesson

A Board with Two Questions: The Right to Tell a Story Within the Story

"Shambuka's Lesson" begins with two questions written on the school board: "Who may study?" and "Who decides?" Jatan's question at the end of Chapter 150 is no longer an activity outside the lesson, but becomes the dramatic organisation of an entire day in the classroom. Jatan places his new admission slip openly on the table rather than hiding it inside a book. The paper admitting him is a visible sign of a new right; the permission to ask questions is invisible. Naval's insistence on the authority that comes with an institutional donation provokes the first clash. He fears that teaching the Shambuka episode will cause conflict, whereas Jatan wishes to read precisely that uncomfortable passage. The opposition produces three distinct speaking positions: teacher, student, and donor.

Padma places three books on the table and does not immediately open them. This suspended beginning creates a dramatic interval different from ordinary school time. A familiar episode concerning Shambuka from Uttara Kanda, a different textual tradition, and an imagined dialogue written for the present are displayed on the classroom board under three separate headings. The novel explicitly identifies its own dramatic adaptation; a reviewer therefore has no basis for treating it as the original epic's "secret authentic dialogue." Within the story this distinction performs a central narratological function: the audience knows that it is watching an interpretative performance, whose characters bear ancient narrative names but whose dialogue has been composed by the contemporary school.

An Imagined Forest Scene, a Halted Ending, and a Child Actor's Unexpected Voice

Sajid's stage displays four seats of equal height, the edge of a forest, a vessel of water, and a half-formed letter. A character playing Shambuka is seated there, but the object of his learning is not fixed in a single word: sometimes letters, sometimes austerity, sometimes the right to his own breath. This uncertainty makes the imagined dialogue a multidimensional aspiration rather than an argument about only one question. The young pupil's entry raises expectations of a conventional teacher–disciple relationship, but the dialogue moves toward the difficult experience of self-education when the way to formal learning is closed. The arrival of an elderly woman adds emotional density: why must the whole burden of changing a rule fall upon one body? Concern for Shambuka's life and the aspiration to social transformation enter into an uneasy conjunction in this question.

The most meaningful moment of the performance occurs when the child playing the guard forgets his line. Padma does not immediately prompt him; in his own words he says that he was merely ordered to bring someone. For an instant, the performance separates from the written script: the child actor's unexpected words become a commentary on the guard character's obedience to orders. This is not a full entry into mythical time, but a visible movement between stage and classroom. The inequality between Shambuka's unfinished letter and the guard's weapon is sharper than an essay in visual form. The author allows the character to speak in favour of questioning, yet the stage is partially freed from directorial control through a small acting error. The unplanned moment gives the story's spontaneous life a stronger voice.

The drama does not end by arriving at and staging the moment of Shambuka's killing. Naval immediately objects that this is not how the conventional account ends. Padma agrees: the staged dialogue is a new imagining, and the difficult ending of the original cannot be erased. Halting the scene is a deliberate formal choice. The work offers the audience neither the easy consolation of an innocent character's survival nor a compulsory emotional response imposed on the children by restaging the death. Birsi divides her notebook into two sections: "What was said" and "What I think." The relationship between following a text and rewriting it independently is concentrated in this visual division. The girl's imagined open book does not erase the original story's actual violence; it opens a new place for imagination after that violence.

The School Stage and the River Landing Outside: Editing Parallel Plotlines

The chapter is not limited to a single ancient play. The school veranda also receives episodes concerning repairs to Keshari Bin's boat, unpaid craft labour, Malati's incomplete water supply, Gopal's map bearing the name "Tirsula," Sushila's seed site at "Bardari," and the working days lost by Reva. At first glance this parallel expansion may appear a digression from the main subject; structurally, however, it is the social echo of Shambuka's question. The play asks "Who may ask?" Outside, the stories raise different choices: "Has the boat been sold or not?", "The tap has been installed, but has water arrived?", and "Can someone's remembered river name serve as a measurement?" The actors' stage and the craftspeople's meeting are not imitations of each other; they represent independent worlds of lived questions.

Keshari holds firm to her decision not to sell the boat, but will not carry passengers before the cracked plank has been checked. A limited arrangement is made to pay part of the undisputed wages from a shared fund. Malati does not merely object to maintenance charges; she asks about the value of service on the days when the tap has been dry. A month-long trial is arranged, but her water pot is still empty that evening. The subplot about river names and maps makes geography itself a shifting narrative space. Another name for "Tirsula" may endure, but the chart from an old boat is not direct evidence of today's water supply. Sushila's seed figures will not be published without notes on the condition of the soil. In these episodes the answer to "Who decides?" on the classroom board disperses beyond the voice of any one teacher.

Jatan creates an unforced connection among these parallel experiences inside school: Keshari's book contains the price of the boat, Malati's book concerns water, and the other book contains Shambuka. The child's comparison does not erase the differences among these narrative languages; rather, it asks how action can be judged after words have been written down. Instead of the teacher's interpretation, the child's question directed toward reality becomes an active coordinator of the plot. Padma asks Jatan's permission before changing the meaning of his final answer. Here the teacher's development is expressed not in instruction but in the act of limiting her own power to revise another person's words.

Temporal Levels, Pauses Between Scenes, and an Artistic Objection to the Performance

The story begins and ends on a school day in Phagun. Within that day, the staged "ancient" time is itself rebuilt as imagination: the play's scenes, returns to the classroom, the municipal committee on the veranda, and

the cart carrying a potter's wheel occupy different narrative levels. "Intertextuality across two temporalities" is relevant here, but the ancient scene must not be mistaken for autonomous history presented without any mark of its fictive character. The author states clearly that Shambuka's speech is new dialogue written for this stage. That is the most important artistic discipline of this self-conscious form of narration. At times, however, the dramatic dialogue speaks the modern language of rights with excessive lucidity, so that the bodily danger of the imagined forest diminishes and intellectual debate takes its place.

A second limitation is the density of subjects. The Shambuka play, Reva's presence as a guardian, Naval's donation, Keshari's boat, Malati's tap, Sushila's seeds, Gopal's place-names, and Shakuntala's pot—all gathered so neatly beside a school in a single day—look to some extent like a composition organised to support a concept. In particular, every subplot repeats a balanced declaration that "the whole matter is not yet resolved." Yet uncertainties in the characters' language—the child forgetting his lines, Birsi's crooked letters, the empty water pot, and the blank meeting point on Jatan's drawing—prevent the novel from becoming entirely a planned lesson in morality.

The final scene is powerful. The first question has not been erased from the board; a new one is added beneath it: "Who changed their mind after reading?" Jatan does not raise his hand; his gaze rests on Shakuntala's soft clay pot. This visible object carries the classroom lesson into the next chapter, 152, "The Debt of Clay." The lesson ends not upon a final answer but upon a changed gaze after the question. The movement of that gaze contains the momentum of the plot to come.

Chapter 152 — The Debt of Clay

A Broken Water Pot and the Possibility of Another Form: A Tactile Opening

"The Debt of Clay" begins at the broken rim of the water pot scratched when the cart stalled beside the school in the preceding chapter. The final emblem of one chapter becomes the first material event of the next. Shakuntala Pandit removes the fragments of half-fired clay. The complete vessel cannot be made whole again, but the clay can be moistened and kneaded into a new shape. This distinction subtly anticipates the plot's eventual reconstruction: damage is not denied, but new possibilities can arise from the material of the damaged object. The instruction "Write the basis of measurement" on the granddaughter's examination paper and the broken pot in her grandmother's hands form parallel scenes. Measurement

is not simply a number in a book but a material experience of the price of work and of domestic labour.

The granddaughter asks in which ledger the cost of the pot should be entered. Shakuntala takes out the slips for four consignments separately: two accepted deliveries to the school kitchen and two consignments whose payment is disputed. The story turns the distinction into an intergenerational conversation rather than a mechanical classification. From the common experience of something "breaking," the girl reaches the difficult question of cost; Shakuntala explains the different fates of "my broken pot" and "a vessel already accepted before." The narrator does not make the grandmother an all-knowing instructor. When she shows Niru the actual fracture in the pot, the limits of Shakuntala's experience also become visible. Knowledge here develops through the practice of hands, a failed vessel, and the time of the next inspection.

The Granddaughter's Future, the Nephew's Fear, and Inheriting the Potter's Wheel: Changes in Relationships

The chapter's first dramatic conflict develops with the arrival of Shakuntala's nephew. Concerned about the wheel's future, he wants an inheritance document drawn up immediately in the granddaughter's name. The novel does not ridicule his fear: the kiln roof leaks, the elderly woman's hands are growing tired, and without a successor the family's craft tools may cease to be used. But he assumes that the girl's mind and age have already been settled for her. The granddaughter says she does not want to abandon clay work; she wants to study bridges and measurement. Shakuntala refuses to set the family wheel and the granddaughter's future in unavoidable opposition. The conversation thus turns not on a simple binary of inherited craft against education, but on the difference between wanting to learn a craft and being compelled to inherit it.

The wheel, kiln, and tools are listed according to their separate present uses. Shakuntala establishes an interim operating arrangement, while lawful ownership is left open pending examination of all family claims. During this process the nephew ceases to be a uniformly antagonistic figure. Initially he wants a document at once; midway through, he is willing to suggest showing the wheel to the teacher; and at the end he notices a mathematical error in the granddaughter's answer and listens to her alternative method. This subtle change is demonstrated not through exhortation but through a different sequence of actions in the shared courtyard. Nor is the granddaughter a passive symbol of "modern education": she looks at the clay wheel, imagines filling the mould with water, and does not put her hand upon the wheel before finishing her

examination. Her small decision to choose her own time is an act of agency directed toward the future.

Four Consignments, Niru's Dues, and Dhani's Canal: The Expanding Geography of Subplots

The office scene expands around the outstanding payments for four consignments. An order is made releasing partial payment for the two undisputed consignments; the other two await separate inspection. Seeing a clause in the first order stating that every outstanding amount has thereby been finally settled, Shakuntala stops the signature and obtains a revised page. It would be hasty to describe the scene as a resounding heroic victory: all the cash is not received that day. The actual change is that the character prevents a long debt arising from past work from disappearing into one small payment made in the present. The dual movement of time—the long arrears of earlier labour and the instant of today's approval—is a major thread in the chapter's narrative temporality.

Niru Kumal insists that work at the shared kiln and work done in Shakuntala's household must not be absorbed under one family name. The reader sees solidarity among craftswomen, but the story does not erase the wages due to separate individuals within it. Nor does the narrative treat similarities between the work of Kumbhars and Kumals as proof of identical lineage. Niru's work slip reaches Shakuntala at the doorstep toward the end. This small concluding gesture reminds us that alongside domestic laughter and the granddaughter's schooling, someone's payment is still outstanding. The novel therefore refuses to make the end of a happy domestic scene equivalent to the achievement of economic justice.

The episode concerning Dhani Rajbhar's canal extends the chapter's geographical limits. Without water reaching the rented field, the crop is in danger; but if only the upper canal is opened, the houses downstream may flood. The subplot does not declare a clay pit and an irrigation canal to be the same geographical site: they remain different problems in different places. The old measuring sheet for the Kareh and Ratan's remembered place-name "Jibachh" are long-distance echoes of earlier water narratives. Ratan himself acknowledges the difference between the landing in his memory and the place shown on today's map. Nevertheless, this echo of social geography delays Shakuntala's main plot for a time, as the reader travels from debts owed for the wheel to the history of the river. The artistic justification for this expansion comes when the granddaughter's studies of measuring water bring the narrative back inside the home.

Courtyard, Office, and Clay Pit: Temporal Composition and Bodily Memory

The external time extends from dawn until late at night: reshaping the clay pot, the family dispute, the office decision, the date of the next inspection of the clay site, the granddaughter's examination, a small evening gathering, and distribution of slips at night. Into this enter fragmentary retrospections concerning the four consignments, old ownership papers, a clay-pit collapse during the rains, old measurements of the Kareh, and childhood memories of Jibachh. The total time therefore exceeds the question "How much money was received today?" and becomes the many-layered question "Whose work came before, and what remains for the next generation?" The narrator generally observes events in the third person, but focalisation becomes acutely sensitive near Shakuntala's painful hands, the granddaughter's examination sheet, the nephew's silence, and Niru's unpaid dues.

On her examination paper the granddaughter writes that where no tap reaches the house, time spent fetching water cannot be measured by one universal rule. In this question Malati's incomplete water supply from the preceding chapter returns in a new educational form. The girl does not erase the mathematics lesson; she adds a separate question drawn from what she has witnessed beneath it. The tension between education and craft is thus constructed not simply through resolution, but through two ways of knowing coexisting in one notebook. Shakuntala says that she must have the pain in her hands examined; the nephew does not laugh. Within the account of preserving the potter's wheel, the cost borne by the ageing body appears without anyone making a speech.

The Ending with Three Bundles, the Risk of Metaphor, and the Chapter's Artistic Place

The concluding arrangement is unmistakable: safety and access at the clay site, payments still due for vessels, and the granddaughter's schooling form three bundles placed in one chest, but not combined into one. The arrangement makes visible a recurring critical principle of this chapter and of Uttara Kanda as a whole: linked questions arising from people's lives cannot be settled by treating one as payment for another. The clay from a broken pot can be kneaded again; even when some loss is irreversible, a new form of work is possible. "Debt" in the title thus spreads beyond unpaid money to the granddaughter's future, the older woman's treatment, and a safe path to the clay pit.

An artistic objection is necessary alongside this reading. So orderly a discussion, in one day, of four office bills, safety at the clay site, agreement over the canal, old river names, family inheritance, the granddaughter's

schooling, and Niru's wages somewhat diminishes the scattered uncertainty of reality. Every character speaks with exceptional clarity in the language of "separate headings," "separate papers," and "partial approval." Repeated continuously, this pattern can sometimes make the story resemble a register of questions. Yet the morning dew, the shard of a broken pot, the wobbling centre of the wheel, the girl's laughter over mathematics, and a lump of wet clay at night give these lucid statements an experience of form and touch. In this tactile episode, character development resides in the body of the scene, not only in spoken rules.

Anushasana Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 149–152

From a Notice to a Face, from a Face to a Lesson, from a Lesson to Clay: The Story of an Object Sequence

These four chapters construct a meaningful transition: a yellowing accusation notice at the school (149) leads to two mobile phones and an edited image (150), to the board displaying the question of Shambuka and a performance script (151), and finally to Shakuntala's broken pot and three bundles (152). The objects have different physical forms, but their narrative meanings are united by a question: who holds the power to make decisions about a person, an event, or a future? Janki determines the words of her own public rebuttal; Sajid does not expose the face of the child in the original play to an uncontrolled audience; Birsi creates separate sections for the original statement and her own imagining; and Shakuntala refuses to make an immediate document assigning ownership of her granddaughter's future. Across this sequence, the right to narrate changes over time: a person who suffers an allegation becomes one who answers it, and a questioning child becomes the centre of the next narrative.

The internal causal links are explicit. The old notice left at the end of Chapter 148 initiates the story of Chapter 149. The edited video returning at the end of Chapter 149 becomes the first crisis in Chapter 150. Jatan's question about Shambuka at the end of Chapter 150 determines the classroom in Chapter 151. The final gaze of Chapter 151 rests upon Shakuntala's clay pot, and Chapter 152 begins with its broken edge. These transitions are not formal announcements of "the next chapter," but the actual re-entry of an object or question. They create a sense of continuity in the narrative current across the extended middle of a large, 216-chapter novel.

A Comparative Arrangement of Narrative Time, Place, and Voice

The present in all four chapters is bound to the almost continuous days of Phagun in the school, market, and courtyard. The past generally returns as a present object is opened: a copy of an earlier allegation, the original theatrical recording, a former application for mobile schooling, the reconstructed dramatic scene of Shambuka, old receipts for vessels, or a memory of the landing at Jibachh. The one distinctly different narrative level is the staged Shambuka scene in Chapter 151, which the novel itself identifies as imagined. These four chapters do not therefore offer a long, unqualified, independent historical narrative set in antiquity, but a contemporary classroom's reenactment of an ancient story.

Focalisation remains predominantly polycentric. Janki's bodily exhaustion, Mohan's trembling hands, Jatan waiting for his slip, Birsi's crooked letters, Malati's empty pot, Shakuntala's worn palms, and the granddaughter's notebook bring the reader into different people's experiences. The social purposes of the words spoken by teachers, employees, boat workers, itinerant families, and craftspeople vary. Even so, the linguistic construction of their statements becomes equally polished and logical too often; full polyphony can sometimes resemble an exceptionally well-managed exchange in a legislative assembly. The most effective moments are those in which language falters, an actor forgets his lines, a child does not smile, an elderly woman's hand trembles, or the wheel wobbles to a halt.

Literary Achievement and the Critical Questions That Remain

The achievement of these four chapters lies in making "small-scale solutions" into an art. A rebuttal notice is posted, but the rumour returns; genuine school admission is granted, but the family's lost earnings remain; the play about Shambuka is halted upon a question without erasing the original's difficult ending; Shakuntala receives an order for partial payment, while actual receipt of money, all remaining dues, and the granddaughter's future remain separately open. These unresolved situations are not merely a device for leaving the plot unfinished. They constitute a creative recognition that bodily, economic, and familial timescales sometimes move more slowly than administrative closure.

The chief artistic weakness also arises from the same structure. Many characters repeatedly close their statements in the manner of "a decision has been made about this particular matter, and the rest will remain separate." This repetition can diminish the social differences among their voices. Across all four chapters almost every question produces an orderly application, a narrowly qualified declaration, or a separate register; such plan-led storytelling leaves limited room for unspoken anger, error,

coincidence, and extended silence. Yet the exhaustion that descends upon Janki when she sees the phone, the blank place in Jatan's notebook, the forgotten line in the play, and the newly kneaded clay upon the wheel challenge this planned voice. The next stage of criticism must examine how the consequences of these small corrections change social conduct, and where the rhythm of documentary closure may weigh more heavily than the complexity of character.

Chapter 153 — Measuring the River

Changing Water, Changing Standards of Measurement: The Narrative Grammar of the Opening Scene

"Measuring the River" begins not with an administrative announcement but with the bamboo sounding pole in Hira Sahni's hands. Dawn light, a wet cord, a displaced knot, and a line of grass left upon the mud: these four concentrated visual signs admit the reader into a world where the water's present condition does not fully agree with the traces of its past. The narrator does not disclose the river's definitive meaning in advance. Instead, the scene is displayed, and only then do we hear Gopal Majhi's question and Hira's self-doubt. Hira's remark that today he will see "where I myself am wrong" removes this experienced figure from the position of an omniscient guide and establishes him as a changing consciousness capable of learning. Consequently, measuring the river becomes not merely the subject of the story but a way of telling it: the meaning of each mark depends upon its time, location, and observer's perspective.

The presence of the second pond-desilting work team in 2040 gives the episode a definite social time. Before excavation begins, a decision is taken to examine the outflow route for the water, the safe passage for boats, and the remuneration of the workers. At this point, the story moves from water to labour and from labour to public decision-making. Gomati stops a young man carrying a spade from entering the enclosed area. Her intervention does more than manage risk; it changes the movement of the plot. The novel does not ordinarily close a scene simply by saying "the work began." It extends the narrative through questions of how the work is done, by whom, and at what time. Here the extension is justified, because the movement of water and the bodies of workers are exposed to danger at the same physical site.

From Measuring with the Body to Measuring with Instruments: Focalisation and a Character's Self-Correction

Hira's sounding pole bears coloured bands for "knee-deep," "waist-deep," and "man-deep." When the new assistant treats the height of his own knee

as a universal measure, Hira demonstrates the differences in bodily proportions. "My body is my memory" does not dismiss experience; it acknowledges experience's limits. The scene is initially focalised through Hira's embodied knowledge, then makes room for Tara's measuring tape and the assistant's perspective. This change of focalisation breaks the monopoly of any single character's voice. Tara does not reject the old signs outright; she establishes a fixed reference point and a separate register of corrections. Hira himself explains that when he cut the top of the bamboo again, he failed to realign all the coloured bands. This small admission produces an actual development in his character: the authority of experience grows through self-correction, not through declaring itself beyond dispute.

The three testing points along the two channels provide the reader with a small sequential map of the site: firm sand, soft silt, and a current that delivers a powerful shove. The same method will not work at all three. The ensuing trial-boat scene translates this narrative principle into action. Hira initially instructs the boat to turn left, but on hearing Gopal's observation of the current and seeing Aditi's signal, he immediately decides to turn right. This is not merely an illustration in dialogue: it is a genuine change in a character's decision. The boat reaches the safe side; Hira then marks the location of his mistake in pencil himself. In this brief scene, the promise made at the opening has a consequence. Yet the successful completion of the voyage does not produce an ending in which the route is declared open in every season. The short passage opens under conditions of limited daylight, repeated measurement, and a trained boatman. The narrative preserves the difference between "it has been done" and "it will remain possible."

Names, Memory, and Geographical Time: A Restrained Use of Analepsis

In the fifth textual passage, Gopal distinguishes the names "Tirsula" and "the northern bend of Tilwaha." To a listener this might appear a small linguistic distinction, but a boat taking the wrong bend could put living people at risk. The reader thus understands that narrative space is not merely visual background: specific names are bound to possibilities of action. Both an old rescue slip and today's site inspection enter the narrative, but the narrator does not reproduce that past event as a separate, fully realised scene. The principal timeline of this chapter is the present work team of 2040; the past enters the present through notebooks, names, and the characters' spoken memories. The preliminary indication of a "two-period intertext" in the earlier narrative should not, in this passage, be mistaken for an independently staged scene from an ancient epic.

Ratan's recollection of two peepal trees in the forest is a moving example of this temporal design. The two trees remembered as standing together prove to belong to different periods: one fell in a flood, while the other was planted later. Ratan's voice carries more grief than shame, so the correction of old knowledge does not become a story about the defeat of a mistaken elder. Keeping the present distance distinct from the directions of his childhood, he takes back his private notebook. One portion of it, released with his consent, will enter the public work record. In this way, the narrative gives a place both to the living rhythm of private memory and to the present use of a public map without conflating them. The reversed route-name in Gopal's old rescue paper is also corrected; but that correction does not, by itself, establish the whole account of who gave which order during the disaster of 2039. Instead of reconstructing a single, exclusively true past, the novel places incomplete memory beside a changing landscape.

The name "Kamala" in the eighteenth passage and the stony current in the nineteenth further widen this setting. Shakuntala's document concerning the price of clay is not a map of an ancient confluence; nor does Dhani Rajbhar's claim concerning a seasonal watercourse establish ownership of the land by itself. From the reader's perspective, the crucial issue is not which name remains eternally true, but how much meaning the narrator permits a particular object to bear. The proliferation of names creates possibilities within the plot; present experience of the site places limits upon those possibilities. This restraint gives the river narrative a particular artistic credibility.

Living Labour Amid the River: The Narrative Presence of an Absent Character

The demand that working hours and rates of pay be measured separately recurs throughout the chapter. Madhu Kevat's objection, the experiences of women whose doorways were blocked, the carriage charges for moving silt, and the time needed to measure the washerwomen's landing platform all prevent the narrative from becoming a one-dimensional depiction of hydrology. Urmila's absence is particularly significant. Her death has already been verified; the narrator does not bring her into the current work-team register as an imaginary participant. Sarita recalls an objection Urmila once made while alive, but the women now working give their measurements themselves. The memory of the dead does not displace the decisions of the living. Urmila's unfinished washing ledger returns as a physical paper: grief persists within the narrative not as one isolated scene of lamentation but as responsibility for the future.

The granddaughter asks how accurate numbers can be preserved on a bamboo pole that wears down. Her question places the chapter's imagery in the consciousness of a new generation. Her function resembles that of an external reader asking how far old marks may be trusted upon a changing object. The scene unfolds amid cooked rice, the smell of mud, and a child's laughter; the abstract discussion of measurement is therefore not separated from embodied life. The tilted post at Rajinar and the sight of four different public notices indicate that "open" and "closed," in a story about measuring the river, may describe different places on the same day. An effort to compress the complexity of the story-world into a single board proclaiming victory itself becomes the subject of a character's objection.

The Red Cord, the Old Knot, and the Blank Signature: The Shape of the Ending

In the final scene Hira does not tear away the old coloured bands. He ties the new measurement beside them and places a short thread upon the old knot. The image gives a new meaning to the wet cord of the opening. Measurement has changed, but memory has not been erased; a short safe route has opened, not permission for all time; wages have been entered, but not all arrears have been paid. The final blank signature box is left for Ramani's forthcoming question. Thus the dispute over the public landing and fishing rights in Chapter 154 already exists as an internal possibility of the plot. The chapter ends with a decision, but its decision deliberately leaves room for the next scene.

The chapter's achievement is to weave the movement of water, bodily knowledge, remembered places, and working time into a common yet multiply focalised story. Its limitation arises from that same quality. The sequence of Tilwaha, ponds, stony channels, Rajinar, the mouth of the baha, numerous craft workers, and accounts of unpaid dues distributes the reader's attention across many places within a single chapter. Most characters state the limits of their demands in exceptionally clear, concise administrative language; as a result, the unfinished, harsh, or awkward voices of spontaneous disagreement are sometimes less audible. Even so, Hira's decision aboard the boat, Ratan's grief, and the double marking on the final bamboo pole preserve living visual centres within this potentially list-like expansiveness.

Chapter 154 — The Document of Consent

The Locked Gate and Three Papers: A Dramatic Opening Built Around Place

The blank signature box at the close of the preceding chapter becomes a concrete conflict in this one: a new lock upon the permanent landing at Barki Pond. Renu Gondhi unties a wet rope; half the bamboo barrier has been removed, but the iron gate in the middle remains closed. A notice carries the words "Entry prohibited without the consent of the fishing-lease holder." The combination of this written statement and the visible gate establishes the opening resistance. Renu's question concerns an ordinary right of access to water, but its dramatic force lies in the distinction between a lease to produce fish and public use of the landing steps. The characters demand the original annexure to clarify that distinction. The narrator does not accept the half-sentence as final truth without making its disputed meaning visible.

Ramani Bind's arrival makes the opening scene polyphonic. Renu seeks a path down the steps to fill her water pot, while Ramani seeks a safe place to spread fishing nets and recognition of her labour. The two women do not repeat the same communal slogan. Testing the loose stone on the third step and the safe upper path adds physical resistance to the dispute over rights. Thus the two easy endings—"open the entire landing" or "keep it entirely closed"—both become untenable. The story turns toward three documents: public passage, fish production, and the timing and privacy of washing and bathing. The platform becomes a temporary stage, the three papers supply three lines of scenic action, and the exchanges between characters form three distinct axes of conflict.

Renu and Ramani's Parallel but Unequal Struggles: Polycentric Perspective

Renu's old receipt is an object that brings the wasted office journeys of the past into the present. Her account concerns household water, access for patients, and the working time of washerwomen; Ramani's ledger records netting thread, night watches, and the labour of women sorting fish. Although they support each other, the purposes of their statements remain different. In the end each woman signs a separate draft, and each returns home carrying her own object—Ramani her net, Renu her water pot. Through this parallel composition, the characters cease to be abstract representatives of "women's rights"; their distinct acts of living become visible.

The narrator moves the focal centre at intervals among Ramani, Renu, Rama, Tara, and other characters. The leaseholder's representative also advances arguments concerning fees and the security of fishing nets. He is certainly an opposing party, but the possibility of actual damage to nets is not excluded entirely. Rama does not immediately declare a final decision on ownership: the representative's dissent is recorded, and the safe upper passage is opened provisionally. In the twentieth passage, Renu reaches that open section carrying her pot. This brief scene is the result of the long sequence of debate. She makes no victory speech; she fills water and goes home. The chapter's achievement seems more credible in this everyday action, because the reader witnesses the use of a right rather than its abstract proclamation.

Permission, Translation, and Private Papers: Levels of Narration

From the eighth through the twelfth textual passages, the story moves away from the lease dispute and interrogates the meaning of consent itself. A decision is made not to open five files containing protected names at the public meeting. One woman permits an audit of accounts but does not permit publication of her first name or home address. The two separate spaces for signatures create a subtle turn in narrative action: a character's "no" also produces an event. Here the documents are not lifeless objects; they indicate the limits within which a character's private voice may circulate.

Hira Meche's dispute approaches this structure from another direction. His thumb impression appears on an agreement, but its language had not been explained to him. When an independent translator brings out the distinction between "repairing a passageway" and "long-term exclusive use," the process of treating the earlier document as final consent is halted. In narratological terms this is a scene of "rereading": the meaning of an already existing text changes later, while its physical existence is not erased. The meaning of words spoken or not spoken in the past is remade through the present scene of speech. The translator's wages are mentioned separately, so that the independent worker who makes the change of language possible does not disappear from the scene.

Bodily Privacy, the Mother's Name, and the Memory of Labour: Converging Subplots

The disputes about the washing platform, bathing times, and public photography extend the chapter's central theme to the visibility of bodies. Champa does not disclose her medical experience publicly. She tells the meeting only that inspecting public steps and publishing an image of somebody's body are different actions. Her speaking time is short, but its narrative effect is profound: declining to tell the most pertinent private

history is itself a decision. Memory of Urmila after her death returns in another form. A proposal to inaugurate the new landing by announcing free cleaning services in her name is stopped. The deceased person's name must not become an instrument for cancelling the wages owed to living workers. In that decision, the earlier narrative of mourning becomes present action.

Nilima Nurang's mother's name is restored to the marriage register, but permission to publish her entire family history is not granted. The letter from Ramani's maternal home containing the name "Gangi" and the old water-rights paper mentioning Bagmati–Bangmatti introduce different textual layers of memory. These names do not establish the precise boundaries of the pond today. The story brings history, private handwriting, and current public works together in time without dissolving them into one document. Consequently, the expectation suggested by the title "document"—that every dispute will finally be settled by a single piece of paper—is thoughtfully reversed. Several registers are necessary here because human activities are many.

The Price of Labour and the Festival Song: Recurrence and Interval

Ramani's daughter raises the question of payment for the knots she ties in the net. The episode extends the continuing story of her mother's labour into the next generation. The daughter is asked for her own view on whether she is currently a worker or an apprentice. On the fourth page of the workday register, cleaning, security, the landing platform, songs, and the cost of bamboo are kept separate. A song for the communal day of remembrance rises from the newly opened landing, but that celebration does not turn anybody's regular paid work into unpaid service. The novel's recurring festival observances are connected here to the memory of previously blocked paths. The temporal interval is experienced not through an enormous flashback but through the song being sung on another occasion.

After the three documents have been summarised, the final scene is unusually rich in implication. The safe upper public steps are opened, while red thread continues to move upon the loose third step. This thread functions like a visual "comma": one route is open, another remains barred. Ramani takes her net, Renu her pot, and Ruhani her confidential envelope, and they go in different directions. In this divided ending, the polycentric narrative finds its beauty. Yet there is an important critical limitation: nearly every character speaks in such cleanly classified official language that the natural inequalities of expression in an actual dispute become less visible. More contradictory, incomplete, or mutually interrupted dialogue might have given the scene greater vitality. Nevertheless, the act of drawing water, the daughter's hesitant question,

and the red thread produce brief dramatic moments that keep the extended description of legal drafts within the realm of narrative.

Chapter 155 — Testimony of Violence

From the Open Landing to the Closed Room: The Dramatic Meaning of a Change of Place

The opening sentence of the chapter retains the "wet voice" of yesterday's song at Barki Pond, but in the very next moment the narrative turns from the open landing toward a safe room in the shelter. This relocation is more than a change of scene. In the preceding chapter, the principal concern was the right to use public steps; here the issue is an individual's control over the public disclosure of his own experience. The song's lingering sound and the silence of the protected room are not opposites but two different social dimensions of experience. At first the narrator gives no name to the man who enters the room. This anonymity is not an artificial device for sensational suspense: narrative distance is adjusted to the man's own choice about how much of his identity he wishes to share. His selection of a low stool near the window, his wish to leave the curtain loosely drawn, and his desire to keep the exit in view present an inner conflict through outward acts, without appropriating his private thoughts.

Ruhani asks, "What do you need first today?" The response unfolds in the order of medical treatment and the right to choose his own words. The man himself states the essential fact that two men subjected him to sexual violence, but postpones details of time, place, and identity. This particular narrative construction brings the reader to an ethical boundary: the story makes known that the event occurred, yet does not construct an elaborate scene of violence that would turn the injured person's body into an object of display. The narrator does not reenact the violence in narrative time; attention remains upon the sequence of present decisions after the event. This is not an absence of the "event" but a deliberately restrained distance from its insensitive visualisation. Keeping the treatment sheet and the page for a statement separate becomes a decisive distinction within the plot.

Trembling Fingers, a Half-Sewn Button, and Two Sentences: The Embodied Time of Trauma

The man's trembling fingers, the half-broken button of his kurta, the partially completed stitching, and his wish to keep the garment near him present the experience of trauma through visual detail without sensationalism. Even after medical treatment, the garment is not forcibly taken from him. The half-sewn button connects an immediate ordinary activity of living with pain that remains unexpressed. Instead of making

the reader witness a fabricated depiction of the assault, the scene acquaints the reader with the present boundaries of the character's body. Such details do not demand an obligatory confession in order to gain access to the "inside" of psychological narrative. The character's inner world is readable through his chosen seat, objects, pauses, and voluntary decisions.

Narrative time progresses through approximately one day: arrival at dawn, treatment, a parallel administrative narrative at midday, a second medical conversation, the proposed meeting with a friend in the evening, and the envelope at night. Despite the limited number of major events, the duration feels psychologically slow because each decision is allowed time for hesitation, alternatives, and revision. A particularly important scene occurs in the twenty-first passage: before meeting his friend, the empty stool is moved farther from the door. The man writes only two sentences: "I am alive. I will not tell everything yet." The narrator does not fill the silence between those two sentences. This is a precise literary decision in a narrative of trauma. The reader's curiosity remains unsatisfied, but that incompleteness does not signify confusion in the character's experience: it marks a conscious boundary around his authority to tell his story.

Care, Conversational Distance, and the Narrator's Restraint

Rukhsana prevents the openly displayed food register from being brought into the room. A healthcare worker supplies the necessary treatment sheet but does not turn it into a declaration identifying the perpetrators or delivering a final judgment. Champa leaves water outside the door and goes away; when permission to enter is not given, the scene does not recast this as an insult to her. Setting a time to meet a friend, preserving the possibility of postponing it again, and choosing to continue treatment are decisions that prevent the character's personhood from being reduced to the label "victim." The writer's restraint is apparent in the refusal to elevate anyone's private story to a communal stage merely to demonstrate courage. The man says that his story should not become the institution's "success story." That boundary appears to apply equally to the novel's own procedure of narration.

An unknown person attempts to gain entry by displaying an identification card, but the card alone does not open the door to an interview. As an event, this small refusal matters: the plot does not slide into the familiar pattern, "Now an authorised person has arrived, so a detailed statement will follow." A volunteer asks whether silence will allow the offenders to escape—a genuine voice of objection. Zubaida does not dismiss the question, but neither does she subject the injured person's private decision to collective public anger. Here polyphony is not merely a succession of people who agree; there is a real tension between the desire for immediate justice and the insistence upon private time. Nevertheless, the volunteer's

disagreement rather quickly becomes a matter of training. The narrative could have remained longer with its emotional and social complexity.

Parallel Narratives of Names: Ramani, Renu, Nilima, Rozi, and Niranjan

At intervals, the narrative moves toward the Barki Pond office and other disputes over records. Ramani's name is entered in the shared-use register, but the final ownership of the fishing lease and the question of past proceeds from fish sales remain unsettled. Renu's old paper bearing the name "Dhauri" is a trace of remembered place, not a definitive map of the present river. Nilima's mother's name becomes clear again in the marriage register, but the geographical significance of a personal letter containing "Nima" remains separate. These subplots share a structural feature: an institution external to a person compresses that person's own name and experience into one category, and the character herself challenges that compression.

Rozi Lalbegi's episode occupies a distinctive place within this wider narrative cycle. Her community, occupation, and religious self-description have been merged in the administrative fields. She demands the right to state the three separately. In Niranjan Kisan's case, banking procedures stall because the element "Kisan" in his name is confused with his actual occupation as a farmer. In narrative terms it would be wrong to treat these episodes as events equivalent to the man's experience of violence. Their only similarity is a tension between "the person's own account" and "the description supplied from outside." Keeping the different degrees and kinds of lived experience distinct—violence, identification of workers, family memory, and bank naming—is a condition for understanding the novel's polyphony.

Repeatedly moving from the man's fragile treatment scene to the office's many corrections of names may scatter the reader's emotional concentration. Yet a counterargument can be made: this structure generates a narrative flicker. The person who has endured violence needs time of his own, so the narrative cannot keep surrounding him with questions; meanwhile other people's lives continue. This is an ethical interpretation of the reader's distance, not necessarily proof of complete artistic success. The chapter's test is whether the small details of things and bodies preserve the reader's memory when the strand of violence returns. The half-sewn button, window, plate, low stool, and envelope hold that thread of memory in place.

“Not Yet”: The Language of the Ending and an Undecided Future

In the final kitchen scene the man takes his own plate of food, asks for a safe meeting with his friend rather than a possible overnight stay together, and chooses not to share the room. The security register distinguishes public expenditure from sealed personal details. This unusual arrangement plants the narrative seed for the next chapter, “The Exception to the Rule.” In the final moment the man does not tear up the blank statement sheet; he writes “Not yet” upon it and seals the envelope. Here “no” does not mean a final silence: it delimits the present moment, while “yet” leaves open the future. The final image of the moving cord of a fishing net reconnects the narrative to Barki Pond, but avoids the misleading suggestion that the cord is a metaphor for the private history of his body.

The achievement of this chapter lies in its restrained dramatic method. Violence itself does not become a visual spectacle; the options held by the character become genuine turns in the plot; and amid numerous subplots the autonomy of one person’s silence remains protected. A limitation is that institutional figures speak comparatively appropriate words at almost every sensitive moment, which can diminish the broader dramatic difficulty of arbitrariness, confusion, or enduring institutional failure in a real setting of assistance. Despite that limitation, the final words “Not yet” are exceptionally powerful, because instead of a resolution they make the right to one’s own time the principal narrative achievement.

Chapter 156 — The Exception to the Rule

A Form with Three Boxes and No Fourth: A Story Beginning with an Absence

The chapter begins with blue paper soaked by rain and hundreds of identical printed forms: name, permanent address, reason for complaint—three boxes, with no fourth box anywhere. The private choices of the man subjected to violence in the preceding chapter now demand a place within an institutional structure. Dramatically, the “missing box” is not a new protagonist, but it is the concrete object around which a new conflict forms. The rain-blurred letters on the noticeboard outside and the inflexible boxes on the forms inside create a pair of contrasting images: the words outside are being erased, while the printed form within remains rigidly fixed. The story asks how a person whose life will not fit these fixed boxes can gain access.

Zubaida prevents a proposal to attach a complaints board beside the old food-distribution window. This refusal makes an important spatial turn in the plot. The new counter will be set up on the rear veranda, with the

seated visitor's eyes and the papers at the same height; a curtain will be optional. Architectural details here create narrative meaning. Within the same building, separate places are made for public food, private complaints, and corrections of records. The organisation of space becomes an organisation of social relations. A character's autonomy is made visible not through an admonition from the narrator but through the arrangement of walls, windows, shifts, and hours.

Debating the Meaning of an Exception: The Characters' Polyphony

Rama raises the questions of consistency in rules and convenience for the staff; Ruhani distinguishes identical forms from equal access. The narrative does not construct a cheap opposition in which one character supports "evil rules" and another represents "liberation." Rama herself asks who will decide, within how many days, and where an appeal will lie. These questions move the chapter's conflict from immediate relief for an individual toward the durability of an institutional arrangement. The man from the preceding chapter points out the window but refuses permission for his experience to become a training example. For the reader, this is a living continuity: the plot does not immediately convert one character's wound into a public exhibit, but allows his chosen boundary to change the language of the new procedure.

In the sixth textual passage, four distinct rules emerge. Medical treatment, a formal statement, and publication require separate consent; immediately necessary services and audits of accounts proceed at different speeds; the receipt number is distinct from the person's identity; and withdrawing an application must not lead to cancellation of services already provided. Counted merely as a list, these might scarcely qualify as storytelling. Yet each rule connects with a particular scene from the preceding chapter. The blank statement page, private medicine slip, and public expenditure register of Chapter 155 return here as separate fields in the new form. Thus the story redistributes the meaning of its earlier objects in a later chapter.

Anita, Basanti, and Amla: Parallel Stories of Different Experiences

The worn edge of Anita's old receipt provides a small visual sign. An erroneous caste classification sent her earnings application to the wrong counter. She chooses a confidential meeting rather than an open assembly. Her central narrative demand is that correcting the error must not cause new injury by republishing irrelevant details of her family. The chapter tests the new rules concretely for the first time through Anita's experience: a complete personal copy, a limited public status, and no withholding of uncontested wages. The novel does not claim that all the loss is immediately made good. Anita's action of placing the paper straight in her bag gives bodily expression to a small, partial change.

In Basanti Pan's life a distinction emerges between the administrative equivalents "Pan," "Sawasi," and "Panar" and the identity she expresses in her own words. Her worry over betel leaves drying in the market links her office visit to the time of earning a livelihood. Later, the image of sprinkling water over the scraped edges of the betel leaves returns to this initial concern. Through the recurrence of an object, the abstract problem of revising language becomes connected with the cost of time spent away from the market. Amla Sarbariya arrives carrying three separate covers for three families and knots tied in red thread. The government apparatus proposes one collective number; Amla preserves the distinction between a shared correction of spelling and individual entitlements. In the end, the three red knots are loosened, but the three receipts remain independent. This correspondence of objects at the beginning and end gives visible form to the character's decisive intervention.

The three women's stories are not connected merely by one slogan. Anita's problem is misclassification into a social category; Basanti's is the disappearance of a term used in self-identification; Amla's is the tendency to compress separate families' applications into one number. Parallel editing returns the reader repeatedly to the same counter, each time shifting focalisation to a person bringing a different object: a worn receipt, a green leaf, a red thread. This polyphony succeeds in a substantive sense only if the particular harm suffered by each character is preserved. The novel largely maintains this difference. Yet as almost every episode resolves in much the same sequence of "receipt, order, outstanding inquiry," the rhythm becomes predictable.

Form, Touch, and Access to Knowledge: The New Counter's Multiple Modes

Zubaida devises three differently shaped slips: assistance, correction of records, and confidential communication. Colour alone is judged insufficient, so a means of recognising the signs by touch is added. A question from a child in Sanket's class briefly interrupts the scene; instead of supplying only an answer, Padma places a sample in the child's hands. This episode recalls the multimodal teaching of Chapter 147, without simply repeating that earlier chapter. Here the student's experience changes the practical form of institutional access. Narratively, the distinction between "hearing a rule" and "understanding a sign by touch" also makes the reader's experience material. A scene involving an elderly couple and a blurred photograph repeats the question differently: the timescale of ordinary food needs differs from that of an appeal for a special grant. A meal is provided immediately, while the slip survives until the next day. The scene depicts not the completion of all work but an adjustment among different narrative durations.

Questions of the counter's budget, staff shifts, training, and rest reactivate the novel's central concern with labour. If the new arrangement operates only through the invisible, unpaid time of Ruhani, Zubaida, and Rukhsana, the earlier chapter's vision of freedom will itself be weakened. Rukhsana does not abandon food distribution to assume an indefinite burden of confidential hearings. Her refusal constitutes continuing development of character: the language of "help" must not impose a compulsory new burden upon someone already engaged in service. The mention of workers' embodied time as the narrative system expands creates structural continuity.

The Sound of River Names and a Foreshadowing of Records in Motion

In the eighteenth and nineteenth textual passages the itinerary for a river journey becomes complicated by the similar-sounding names "Tilwaha," "Tilayuga," and "Tilayugba." Gopal Majhi explains that likeness of sound could change the landing at which travellers arrive. Rachna decides to ask separately for the pupils' current pick-up points. The connection with the earlier river-measurement chapter is clear: once the different temporal origins of signs and names are acknowledged, the direction of a journey in the present must be determined afresh. This subplot is therefore not merely an information-technology problem but a continuation of the plot's waterside geography. The reminder of travel-expense claims by three families left behind because of an erroneous name again brings characters from different parts of the story-world together.

In the twenty-ninth passage, a proposal emerges for a mobile verification camp operating across boundaries. Instead of the proposed "list of all names," Rama insists on a basis of local consent and distinct rights. This plants a narrative seed for the near future: how will the access procedure made at one counter change as it travels from village to village? The question points toward the more mobile geography of the forthcoming Ashvamedha Parva. No independent scene from the ancient Ashvamedha appears in this chapter; the meaning of the parva's name can be compared with the structure of the narrative that follows. The final slip—"I want to be heard, but not before everybody"—forms a concentrated reversal of the opening form's three boxes. At first the form demanded every detail of a person; by the end an unnamed voice states the conditions on which it will be heard. In that change, the chapter's narrative journey is completed.

Artistic Achievement and the Limits of the Metaphor of Exception

The chapter's principal achievement is to transform administrative design into a narrative through living places, objects, and time: wet blue paper, a low window, equal eye level, slips readable by touch, separate knots of

thread, and the final anonymous note. Characters' private experiences alter public rules, while problems of funding and staff shifts remain as difficulties beyond individual wishes. A particular artistic weakness is that in nearly every episode of correction Rama or Ruhani promptly proposes an appropriate classification, and staff objections are quickly absorbed. The reader can often predict the direction of reform; narrative surprise is diminished. Anita's uncertainty, Basanti's lost earnings, and the lack of permanent authorisation keep this simplicity from becoming an unqualified victory story.

To place an unnamed voice where some names might otherwise appear is not only an ethical success but also a formal choice. A day that begins with the rain of 2040 ends at the edge of a thin stream of water in the night kitchen. Under the same roof, there is not one identical entrance for everyone but the possibility of choosing one's own way. The narrator leaves the future narrative open on this point: the window has opened, but final justice has not been declared.

Anushasana Parva / Uttara Kanda: Overall Narratological Assessment of Chapters 145–156

From the Queue to the Window: An Object-Sequence Across Twelve Chapters

The progression of the twelve chapters of Anushasana Parva rests upon the changing meanings of ordinary things. The ration queue (145) opens the bodily experience of public distribution; Fakira's pass and Sanket's classroom (146–147) reveal different timescales of access to travel and education; Padma's fee (148) exposes the concealed costs of educational labour. Janki's rebuttal, face and evidence, and Shambuka's lesson (149–151) establish a critical distance for the reader between public image, performed narrative, and the right to speak. The debt of clay (152) reveals the complexity of objects and inheritance within a family. The final four chapters (153–156) create a new configuration out of the bamboo used to measure the river, the lock on the landing, a private envelope, and a form divided into three boxes. Through these different objects, the parva repeatedly rereads one central question: how are a person's work, name, and time included in—or excluded from—a list written by someone else?

It would be mistaken to describe this sequence as twelve extensions of a single incident. A pupil's mother tongue, payment for fishing nets, boats on a river, the private time of a person affected by sexual violence, inheritance of clay-working property, and the labour of the deceased Urmila are distinct kinds of event. What binds them is neither one

protagonist nor one lawsuit but recurring objects and memories within the shared geography of everyday public life. There are several dense links by which the close of one chapter becomes the point of entry to another: the clay and water question of Chapter 152 leads into measurement in 153; the unsigned space in 153 leads to the landing in 154; the sound of the public landing in 154 leads to the private room in 155; and the sealed consent paper in 155 leads to the new window in 156. Through this sequence, Uttara Kanda becomes the novelistic time of extended consequences, not simply an appendix after the war.

Narrative Time and Focalisation: Scenes of Daily Routine Amid Prolonged Mourning

The parva's principal present is the social reconstruction of 2040. Memories of the preceding disaster of 2039 continually return, but this does not mean that every chapter contains a self-contained scene of an earlier event. The experience of Urmila's and Naira's absence arises differently through clothing registers, kitchens, schools, and access to the landing. The duration of grief is formed more by personal recurrence than by calendar days. Characters remember the past, but memories of the dead do not substitute for the consent of living workers in the present; this is an important source of the novel's emotional seriousness. Chapters 153–156 contain no separately staged ancient scene from either the Mahabharata or the Ramayana. Their intertextuality works primarily through the names of the parvas and memories of earlier narrative strands.

The distribution of focalisation is one of this parva's broad achievements. The novel approaches the experience of Ruhani, Gomati, Sarita, Janki, Ramani, Renu, Hira, Fakira, Padma, and numerous figures who appear almost as brief pauses in a sentence. Yet "polyphony" does not simply mean a large number of character names. The most effective moments are those in which the limits of different characters' statements produce conflict: Ramani wants space for her nets, Renu wants steps down to the water; a clerk wants one form, a resident wants a confidential window; the man sitting on a low stool wants treatment but not an immediate detailed statement. Such differences alter the reader's experience. External narrative distance, descriptions of objects, and dialogue together open several ways of approaching a character's inner life.

Not Moral Pressure but Narrative Incompletion: The Parva's Final Rhythm

The decisions in Anushasana Parva are usually partial. The upper steps of the public landing open, while the loose third step stays closed. A name enters the shared-use register, but lease payments or ownership remain

unsettled. Correction of an erroneous caste category begins, but earlier lost payments are not fully compensated. A confidential counter opens for a trial period, without permanent governmental approval. There is narrative honesty in this incompletion, for the novel does not manufacture an excessively dramatic conclusion in which one minor event changes everybody's fate. Room remains for the following chapter, and the reader continues to travel behind the unfolding time.

That same method, however, also creates a stylistic problem. Dialogues in many chapters develop according to a similar pattern of objection, acknowledgment, postponement, and revision. Characters repeatedly speak in the idiom of "this is separate, that is separate." Such recurrence reveals the complexity of social life, but at times it makes the individual voices of characters sound alike. When an administrative classification becomes clear by the third or fourth sentence, dramatic tension falls. The staged form of "Shambuka's Lesson," the vulnerable silence of "Testimony of Violence," and the mistaken boat turn in "Measuring the River" are moments in which the novel breaks this procedural rhythm and regains the force of living drama.

Before the Ashvamedha: From Local Places to a Story-World in Motion

The proposed journey at the end of Chapter 156 opens the narrative doorway into the next Ashvamedha Parva. Until now, fixed places such as Barki Pond, the shelter, school, municipal office, and banks of the Tilwaha have returned repeatedly. With the proposal for a mobile verification camp, the next narrative may ask how far these local arrangements will change from village to village. This is not merely an enlargement of space. It raises the question of how someone who has won the "right to choose their own way" will encounter a new authority beyond their home location. On this basis, the distinction between the political reconstruction of Shanti Parva and the everyday operation of rules in Anushasana Parva becomes clear. Earlier the central question was "Who will govern?" Now it is "What kinds of rules live alongside people's steps, names, time, and private voices?"

The overall achievement of this parva is to transform the epic concept of "discipline" from grand proclamations of punishment and command into the distinct lines of ordinary labour, travel, mourning, and privacy. Its most serious artistic limitations are the uniformity of many procedural dialogues, the potential weight of their expansion, and the excessively well-resolved language in which spontaneous disagreement is sometimes expressed. Even so, the sequence of objects developing from the first ration queue to the final anonymous slip gives visible relations to the novel's

extended Uttara Kanda. The concluding anonymous appeal—"I want to be heard, but not before everybody"—preserves the narrative's central concern for the journey ahead.

ASHVAMEDHA PARVA / UTTARA KANDA

Chapter 157 — The Path of the Released Horse

The Horse's Hooves and the Meaning of a Road: The Opening Scene of a New Parva

Ashvamedha Parva opens not with the formal proclamation of a royal victory, but with a craft worker's needle catching as the worker stitches gold-edged cloth upon a horse's back. This small obstruction places a minute scene of labour within the epic's great spatial reach. For the commander, the horse's unhindered movement signifies an extension of authority. Arjuna looks into the horse's eyes and finds an open field rather than a royal command. The narrator does not invent an interior monologue for the horse. Instead, through Arjuna's perspective, the animal's moving body is set against the significance that soldiers attach to orders. These two different fields of meaning create the reader's expectation of the next question: does following the same road imply that everyone has given the same consent? The horse understands nobody's language, yet the people travelling behind it must answer. This distinction becomes direct dialogue in the fourth and fifth passages.

Yudhishthira's pause at the first line of the travel document in the assembly is the narrative's first major arrest of duration. The splendour of royal power contracts into the act of reading one sentence on a page. Before proclaiming victory, he raises the question of the voices of people who live along the route, but does not tear up the document. This unfinished decision prevents the story from becoming a facile sermon about the deliverance of justice. In the third passage, Draupadi places those beyond the army—the people clearing the road, feeding the horse, and doing night service—into the empty margin of the travel document. The main body of the page bears the royal order, while its vacant margin becomes a space for invisible labour. Her sentence, "Where we take labour for the road, we shall pay for it," is not merely an emotional comment. Its consequences appear in the bridge-repair decision of the sixth passage and the payment to a young fodder supplier in the eighth. The narrative thereby tests a small written intervention against subsequent scenes.

A Procession Halted at a Field Boundary: Scenic Duration and a Change of Decision

Immediately after a brief account of passing through two villages without obstruction, the third village opens into a dense scene of sandy soil, freshly sown fields, and feet sinking into the earth. The journey through two

villages passes in summary; several textual passages are devoted to a single field boundary in the third. By expanding duration in this way, an "obstruction" becomes not merely a crisis but a centre for generating meaning. A soldier raises his spear; Arjuna restrains his hand; a woman sets down an earthen water vessel and asks how a boundary that was a field ridge yesterday has become a royal highway today. The juxtaposition of yesterday and today sharpens the experience of social appropriation. Her husband died in the war, but her question is not couched in the language of revenge. She speaks of the time needed by crops and the direction taken by water. The narrator does not dissolve her into a crowd of "unknown villagers," although she remains unnamed. This anonymous presence may be read as a conscious formal choice countering the epic's named victors.

In the sixth and seventh passages, the principal event is not simply halting the horse but changing the meaning of the route. The broken joint of an old bridge, materials from the royal storehouse, the rates demanded by local craft workers, and a check of the bridge's carrying capacity become three new practical conditions. The village head makes clear that permission for the horse to pass does not constitute a surrender of the village's own assembly of justice. Arjuna accepts the decision to write the condition in limited language. The consequence appears in a line he writes himself in the eighth passage: granting a route and declaring subordination to the king are two different records. At the opening, Draupadi had filled the margin of the travel document; now Arjuna writes alongside it himself. This is a small but genuine visual indication of development in character. The text does not, however, claim that he has completely escaped the violence implicit in the Ashvamedha: the desire for victory and possible conflicts in the next region remain.

The roughness of the reins against a young soldier's palm turns a complicated political exchange into bodily experience. Arjuna explains the difference between controlling the reins and possessing authority over another person's life. The soldier does not instantly become an idealistic spokesman; he volunteers to check the knot on the purse containing the workers' wages the next morning. This small act keeps change from stopping at the level of a slogan. Still, Arjuna's and the soldier's responses are comparatively prompt; the reader experiences little prolonged internal resistance. This is one possible artistic limitation of the chapter: certain characters achieve moral reorientation rather quickly in comparison with the profound pressure of the structure of power.

The Vehicle of Phagun and the Ancient Horse: Parallel Editing Across Two Times

The tenth passage suddenly arrives in the final week of Phagun in 2040. The narrator does not treat this temporal cut as if it were the following day in one continuous history. The similarity between the ancient horse's journey and the modern inspection team's vehicle lies in authority and movement; their institutional positions, periods, and people remain distinct. Rama Karna unties a knot on a chest fixed to the roof of the vehicle, because the owner of the papers inside must be informed of the journey. If the horse's hooves in the opening scene imply an expanding power, the vehicle's wheels here make the mobility of administration possible. Yet Rama says, "The right to open a village's door does not reside in the tyres of our vehicle." This is a modern resonance of Arjuna's restricted permission to use the road, not a direct translation of mythic authority.

Through the eleventh to thirteenth passages, the travel order, local permission, the security of original records, verified copies, a closed confidential cover, the translator's wages, and the driver's advance emerge one after another. Dealing with each causes the vehicle to leave half a watch late. The novel does not treat this delay solely as evidence of administrative failure; within the delay it places the names of workers and the ownership of documents. The empty seat with its curtain is especially affecting. It is space reserved for an unknown future applicant whose privacy has already been considered in the team's arrangements. The object does not by itself create a "consenting person," but it forms a temporal anticipation of possible participation.

Farida Qureshi's marketplace subplot turns away from the principal journey to expose the complexity of public reputation. An initial boycott notice is removed and the market association withdraws its order, but outstanding customer complaints and losses from missed sales do not disappear automatically. Farida prevents a sweeping declaration that she has been "exonerated"; she wants information recorded in its correct measure. Two adolescents propose retaliating for an insult with another insult, but Farida stops them. This brief dramatic change connects the character's continuing social injury with a new ethic of action. Customers' fears do not immediately vanish, and employees' unpaid wages remain outstanding. These incomplete consequences keep the story-world from becoming a simple celebration of victory.

Rita's Tools, the Village Library, and the Empty Box for Absence

Rita Ekka's scene adds a second social centre to the travel narrative. A genuine loan secured against her sewing tools is not the same "debt" as the

false guarantee linked to an application for repairing the landing. Separate receipts, separate dates, and a written effort to suspend seizure are concrete changes in the plot; not every debt is cancelled. By deciding to repay what she truly owes, Rita ceases to be merely a victim and becomes the character who determines the very object of her resistance. External focalisation reveals her character through her bag, receipts, and tools, without having the narrator disclose all her inner anxieties directly to the reader.

When a separate space for private applications is established in the village school's library room, a shared public place acquires a new narrative function. Children draw pictures outside while papers bearing names are read within; visual distance creates a boundary of privacy. The village head strikes out "survey complete" and substitutes "first meeting held," separating narrative closure from institutional completion. An older woman's loss of three hours at the market and the jointly agreed time for the next meeting extend the journey's duration beyond office hours. Here travel is not simply distance on a map; it is also time taken away from people's daily livelihoods.

The final two passages again edit between ancient and modern time. Repair of the bridge is completed; the young fodder supplier fills in his own receipt; the village repeats its consent to a limited passage. On the modern table, Rama places two different covers: consent to enter and a corrected claim concerning outstanding payments. The sound of hooves is replaced by the wheels of a vehicle that has cooled after stopping. Sarita asks whether someone who refuses to meet the team today will be entered tomorrow as an "obstruction." Rama chooses to write "awaiting a response." This moment, when the language changes from encroachment to waiting, is the chapter's final dramatic event. It leaves a designed question for the next chapter, "Arjuna's Identity": how can people hear a person's own name and relationship when authority has already named that person?

Achievement and Limitation: The Dramatic Movement of a Continuing Journey

The chapter succeeds in connecting the two temporal streams not by treating their events as synonymous, but through echoes among objects: horse and vehicle, needle and coin, field ridge and route to a school, the empty margin left for labour and the translator's wages, the name written by a young worker and a village's copy of a document. Conversely, an excessively self-conscious pattern of thematic parallels makes some dialogue sound formulaic: almost every side immediately recognises the proper distinction between labour, permission, and separate documents. The gravity of conflict with ancient royal authority is somewhat reduced.

Nevertheless, the sinking foot at the third village, the reins against the soldier's palm, Rita's bag, and Farida's weighing scales create particular lived worlds in place of a repetition of theory. The opening of Ashvamedha is effective not as a celebration of victory but as an unresolved debate among several voices about the meaning of a road.

Chapter 158 — Arjuna's Identity

The Bell at the Palace Gate and the Absent Father: The Narrative Question of Identity

The chapter opens with the brass bell at the gateway of Manipura, the horse's fresh hoofbeats, and the string of Babhruvahana's bow. The sound of the bell makes a distant arrival present. What is a matter of royal command to others becomes, for Babhruvahana, the return of an absent father. His question—"Shall I call him a guest or the overlord of my kingdom?"—brings two different relationships into conflict at the same moment. Instead of guaranteeing a sentimental resolution to the father's homecoming, the narrator keeps the character in a state of questioning. The palace gateway is consequently not only a geographical entrance but a threshold of identity. Chitrangada summons her son only after his training session is complete. By that decision, the narrator does not reduce the years of a mother's labour during the father's absence to a single day of royal drama. She tells her son to respect his father without allowing his subjects to be made into a gift. Her maternal voice is not merely a moral message; it formally anticipates the conflict ahead.

In the third and fourth passages, Arjuna's arrival changes the quiet rhythm of the meeting. A welcome platter, the commander's dissatisfaction, memories of Arjuna's valour, and Babhruvahana's trembling hand together shift the father-son encounter toward a trial of masculinity. The son speaks of the courage needed to save the city from war but also expresses his readiness to lift his bow if royal subordination is demanded. Chitrangada then brings forward the unpaid wages of the workers who built the palace gate. This interruption by an unpaid bill deliberately breaks the elevated pitch of an epic reunion: before speaking of a king's and a son's dignity, remember the labour through which the gate came to stand open. The intervention gives the scene several levels, although the dialogue's exemplary moral awareness can appear too prompt.

Chitrangada, Ulupi, and the Different Times of Motherhood

Ulupi's arrival in the fifth and sixth passages shifts the centre of focalisation. The description of a glimmering garment by the river is given from the restricted viewpoint of a guard, who cannot clearly tell whether

the brightness comes from water running down or from the gleam of thread. This small visual uncertainty keeps the boundary between the supernatural and the everyday open without having the narrator announce that a miracle has occurred. Ulupi has not come to claim authority over Manipura. She questions the danger that Chitrangada's voice may be erased. The memory of Iravan, killed in the war, rises within her, but she does not turn her grief into a story that appropriates another son's mother. Through this exchange, motherhood becomes not a summary of one biological relationship but the prolonged time of different bodies, labour, grief, and choices.

Chitrangada's years of governing, Ulupi's mourning for Iravan, and the upbringing and education of Babhruvahana form three different timelines meeting in one royal assembly. In the seventh passage, three kinds of paper are spread out: the records of Manipura's daily administration, the announcement of the horse's entry, and the register of welcome. The commander wishes to close all three under one royal seal; Chitrangada unties the red cord and sets the first paper apart. The opened knot becomes the scene's concentrated sign: objects bound by one cord do not necessarily have the same meaning. The text does not claim that the reader is encountering an exact historical transcript of the governmental institutions of the classical age. This is an invented ancient scene within the novel, in which a woman's voice represents the extended time of governance.

The Dramatic Irony of Combat Practice: An Expected Death and a Living Answer

The eighth through the eleventh passages form the chapter's climax. The distance between Arjuna and Babhruvahana's bows is measured, and the horse is tied beyond the fighting ground. The first arrow strikes the earth, the second the edge of a crown, and the third cuts the string of Arjuna's bow. The escalating action draws the reader toward the memory of the epic father-son conflict. But where a decisive arrow might be expected, the narrator pauses upon the two severed ends of a bowstring. The text acknowledges that other narratives contain a fatal outcome and an episode in which a naga jewel challenges death; in the scene presented by this novel, Arjuna does not die. The living Babhruvahana tells his father that his mother, teachers, and the grounds of his own kingdom taught him archery. Arjuna acknowledges the years of his absence and takes his son's hand; he does not announce victory.

The special accomplishment here is to activate the expectation of a familiar epic event and then choose another outcome. What the reader might fear as a deadly reunion is transformed into a broken bowstring and

a limited public recognition. The change does not claim to correct the literal text of the original Mahabharata or establish a historical fact; it is an intertextual reconstruction within a modern novel. There is a concrete alteration in Arjuna's emotional disposition. After the harsh challenge of the opening, he tells his son, "You did not lose the years of my absence." Yet the crisis between these stages of mental change takes place in very little scenic time. Although the narrative does not say that damage caused by so many years of absence has been completely repaired after one practice bout, the result can still feel somewhat rapid. Chitrangada's return to the business of governance to hear about repairing a canal deliberately postpones this emotional closure.

The two fragments of the broken arrow—one for Babhruvahana and one for Arjuna—distribute personal remembrance, but Chitrangada orders that the public document remain separate. Babhruvahana refuses the condition that his mother's name be omitted from the song. Personal reunion and independent control over the public account appear side by side. Ulupi, who has remained a witness at the outer boundary, claims neither land nor a son; her presence helps the narrator avoid fixing "mother" into a single unchanging type.

In the thirteenth passage the narrative announces a move "very far from the time of this ancient journey" and enters the shelter in 2040. This explicit temporal divider prevents confusion between ancient and modern characters as though they were people of the same historical period. Kabir examines two copies of an old care register. Rather than demand an immediate answer to a blank in the record of his birth, he writes a slip asking for time to meet the woman who raised him. Naira's death has once again taught him the importance of a meeting delayed too long. In this way, the problem of the absent father in the ancient epic becomes, within the modern novel, a question of absences in the record of caregiving. Chitrangada's years of ruling and raising a child and the embodied labour of Kabir's foster mother are not literally the same, but the plot connects them through the demand to give the extended duration of a relationship its due.

Kabir asking after his foster mother's aching back in the veranda marks a decisive moment in the personal drama. The needle-stitching of a tree on an old woollen blanket, a neighbour's incomplete name, and the two known and one unknown people who stayed awake during a night of illness change a singular account of origin into the story of many caregivers. Kabir does not fill the blank name himself. When he tells Sarita that he has found not a verdict about birth but the path by which "I was kept alive," the central question shifts from "Who gave birth?" to "Who cared for him, and for how long?" Subhadra's right to tell her private

account of his birth remains intact; Kabir does not demand her letter by force.

The Subplots of Durga and Suraj: Unequal Lifetimes Within One Chapter

In the modern narrative strand, episodes concerning Durga Gangai's trade and the duration of Suraj Gangota's debt emerge independently of Kabir's self-identification. Durga rejects a former lending merchant's claim to a monopoly but also accepts a new buyer's condition for returning defective goods. Her decision to enter two spoiled bags as a loss against herself removes her from the convenient uniform image either of a woman who simply endures injustice or of a blameless victor. She receives payment for a small consignment, while half the carriage charges remain unpaid. Suraj has lost his field to river erosion. His debt is not cancelled; instead, the repayment instalments are rescheduled according to his present modest income rather than an estimate of his former harvest. A source paper mentioning "Dhemura" preserves a memory of cartography without making a final determination of current land boundaries.

The stories of Kabir, Durga, and Suraj each conclude with a distinct "ledger" of new responsibilities. This thematic composition is highly self-conscious: every episode preserves separate inflows and outflows, an incomplete name, or a restricted correction. Such a pattern assembles the diversity of lives but carries a risk. When the emotional experience of a woman trader, a farmer, and a family is repeatedly drawn into account books, the narrative may begin to seem excessively prearranged. The smell of the two spoiled bags, Harihar's mud-stained sandals, and the stitching on the blanket break that mechanical possibility. Suraj's warning in particular—"Do not turn a fear that has been postponed into a flag of victory"—establishes a rhythm attentive to the limited outcome of events.

The Double Ending and the Limits of Achievement

In the twenty-ninth passage, the time of Manipura returns once again. Babhruvahana comes to his mother carrying a fragment of the arrow, but Chitrangada directs his attention to the people's decision the next day. In the thirtieth, modern passage, Ruhani sets aside the private envelope, Rama leaves blank the name of the local contact, and Kabir retains the key to the notebook of his foster history himself. The broken arrow fragment and the closed private notebook are not identical objects, but both signify a bounded authority over relationships. The chapter's artistic strength lies in this double ending. A meeting between father and son and a question arising from the memory of lifelong care remain distinct, yet receive a shared formal resonance. A limitation is that the additional Durga–Suraj episodes interrupt the emotional line of the central father-son conflict,

while dialogue often becomes an elegantly organised public ethical statement rather than a character's particular speech. Nevertheless, the bell of Manipura and the stitching of Kabir's blanket make this extended chapter a vivid narrative across two temporal worlds.

Chapter 159 — Records in Motion

A Chest on the Roof of a Worn-Out Bus: The Scenic Construction of Relocation

The chapter begins at the precise present time of "the first dawn of Chaitra 2040." Sarita tightens the rope around a chest fastened to the roof of a dilapidated bus; the driver explains that putting it inside would reduce the space available to passengers. The chest contains no original identity papers, only blank sheets, a receipt book, a floor mat, a covered seal, and a separate envelope for the translator's wages. The list of objects creates an unusual expectation at the outset: no one's private story is yet inside the chest, but there is room for numerous voices not yet written down. Rama asks whether the team should spread the mat on reaching a village before hearing from the people. Sarita replies that they must first ask where they have permission to spread it. Although it is simply an object, the mat becomes a sign of the right of narrative entry. External description and brief dialogue establish the team's future procedures, but those procedures remain tied to a physical action—the tightening of a knot—in the first scene.

In the second and third passages, work that could have been labelled "background" becomes scene in its own right. Rukhsana explains the limits of access to private envelopes, the translator's hours are changed from unpaid "cooperation" to remunerable labour, and Kabir resolves to ask people's wishes before opening his camera. Since Naira's death, Kabir has been recognising the impatience of his own pen. This small act of self-correction echoes his earlier eagerness to publish; the novel does not announce that "he has now reformed" but shows the change through gradual alternatives in his conduct. In the window of the bus, the separate, trembling reflections of Sarita and Kabir form a complex visual image of a shared journey. They travel together without owning each other's experience.

The Name on the Board and the School Veranda: A Multilingual Place

In the fourth passage, the name written on the government signboard differs from the name "the bend by the tree" spoken by an elder. Rather than taking a photograph, Rama records both names and the consent of

the person who gave them. This seemingly minor linguistic difference localises the question of the "village door" raised in the first travel chapter. As soon as people see the mobile camp, they begin forming a queue for relief. Sarita first asks for collective permission. At this point the story frustrates the reader's expectation: the familiar sequence of relief distribution that might follow the sight of a government vehicle is replaced by a conversation about language and place.

The school veranda recurs in passages five and six, then fourteen and fifteen. The old iron post marked with red thread behind Pratima Rajvanshi and the open route used by children present different viewpoints within the same compound. A shop's representative seeks to treat permission to hold the camp as proof of ownership of the land. Pratima changes the position of the temporary table without pronouncing judgment on the original boundary dispute. In the fifteenth passage, Rajo's daughter runs along the open path carrying her notebook. The movement of the child's body turns an abstract map of disputed land into a scene of everyday life. Her running does not settle ownership, but it makes the future of a path that is open today concrete in the reader's experience. The school is not merely a symbol of a court of justice; it is a living chronotope of competing uses—study, shopkeeping, and pedestrian access.

Kumudi's translation notebook turns this multilingual setting into a question of narrative technique. The distinction between "return" and "new migration" changes the time implied by a local experience. Someone has moved from an old workplace to a new home; collapsing that sequence into one administrative term could omit the wages earned in the earlier place. Kumudi is an independent intermediary: she changes the language without appropriating the applicant's story as her own. A young clerk's request to "make it mean just one thing" and a teenage girl's act of writing her mother's name herself shift authority over speech from one hand to another. Instead of imposing a solution through an omniscient narrative voice, the narrator also shows the decisive moment when the translator remains silent.

Ramvati's Travel Document: The Time of Earlier Labour and the Language of a Present Place

The arrival of Ramvati Khatve supplies a principal centre of character for the chapter. Her first travel document and her identity document after marriage had each originally been returned to her, but the two registers had never been reconciled. A brief recollection of that prior event becomes the basis of a new scene of action in the present camp. Ramvati refuses to consider the wages for rice transplantation in an earlier place as a claim that has lapsed because she now lives elsewhere. Her words—"The days I

spent transplanting rice in that field came with me"—present time as a journey attached to the body. A change of address after marriage does not erase past labour. It would be inappropriate to turn this scene into a modern incarnation of an epic figure: it is a contradiction between labour and place within a wholly modern time strand.

The slip bearing the name "Santi" introduces a recurring crisis of similar sounds. A new employee wishes to combine names that resemble one another for rivers; Ramvati insists that the old spelling be preserved as it was. The question at this moment is not a final declaration about "which river is real," but recognition that the personal history of a source-name used during a journey and present geography belong to different times. Ramvati has her claim entered and receives a date for further checking, not the wages withheld from her immediately. Her bundle of beaten rice, the meal time she has lost, and her fear of missing yet another day of transplantation connect the office scene with bodily hunger and the time of a livelihood. Kumudi shares the food with her but does not treat it as a substitute for a translator's wages. A small image of friendship and the separate present reality of paid labour coexist.

A Pawned Bangle and a Shortfall in Expenses: Expanding the Scene at the Second Stop

At the camp's second stop in Simatirtha, a subplot unfolds around Sharda Kasaudhan and an elderly customer's pawned bangle. Sharda herself exposes an error that has caused interest to be charged twice; her brother wants to retain the old rate. The older woman hears the rate spoken again in her own words and chooses a new calculation. The bangle remains in the shop for the time being, but a copy of the corrected amount owed reaches the customer's hands. The distance between an object's physical absence and a new document in hand creates the chapter's unresolved emotional condition. The old woman's sensation of warmth from a right she holds "without the bangle in my hand" is a small literary transformation: administrative text becomes embodied feeling. This is a distinct narrative from Ramvati's wages, because Sharda corrects the wrong calculation in her own business and the customer does not deny her underlying debt.

In passages twenty through twenty-three, new conflict emerges over consent to photography, Kumudi's additional hours, the driver's waiting time, and a proposal for a public donations box. Sarita refuses to finance the administrative journey from money set aside for shelter residents' relief. Additional authorisation is requested from the office; there is no claim that every outstanding payment has immediately been made. This creates a useful narrative rhythm, yet nearly every subplot concludes with a

provisional account, separate slip, or date for a subsequent review. The formal recurrence risks subjecting very different personal experiences to one administrative tempo. Even so, the covered mouth of a water vessel, the driver's weary waiting, and the decision not to open Ramvati's private letter are moments in which the characters' situations restore vitality to the scene.

Three Slips, a Red Pen, and an Empty Chair: The Transfer of Authority to Narrate

In the twenty-fourth passage, the three slips relating to Ramvati, Pratima, and Sharda close in different states of completion: reconciliation of two names is still due, the boundary of the school grounds remains unsettled, and the principal debt survives after the correction of interest on the pawned bangle. The comparison has the small rhythm of a summary of events. But the next four passages turn the narrative toward another meaning. Kabir remembers Naira's old four blank boxes and refrains from hastily making news out of the camp's papers. Rama sees that an initial report compresses Kumudi's, Pratima's, Sharda's, and Ramvati's work beneath one heading, "achievement of the inspection team." With her red pen, Sarita places separate numbers beside each person's work and confines her own name to "coordination."

The empty chest of the opening returns in the final passage as a receipt book now filled with entries. It is not, however, a material emblem of "all problems solved": it holds spaces awaiting payment of numerous unpaid amounts. On returning home, Sarita does not place the camp's papers on Naira's empty chair. Public achievement is not allowed to encroach upon the private site of mourning. Sarita says, "I will not take credit for work that I only helped to organise." The final sentence is an explicit narrative seed for the next chapter, "Sarita's Contribution." To read Chapter 159 only as an independent report on a travelling camp would therefore be inadequate. It bridges a path made for individual voices and the forthcoming struggle over public authorship.

Stylistic Achievement and Limitation: Records Move, but How Many Bodies Must Move?

The chapter's overall design rests upon the opposition between movement and stillness. The bus moves while original documents remain at the office; names emerge in different places while the old days of rice transplantation travel with the worker; the bangle stays in the shop while its corrected account travels home; Naira's chair remains where it was while Sarita's red pen writes new acknowledgments. Kumudi's autonomy as a translator adds genuine polyphony. The limitations are also evident: the rhythm of

sudden disagreement repeatedly follows “photograph, clarification, separate slip”; some officials appear to exist solely to propose a simplified mistake; and an appropriate character brings forward most correct alternatives almost immediately. Despite these weaknesses, Ramvati’s missed transplantation work, the old woman’s bangle, and Naira’s empty chair keep these events from dissolving into procedural dialogue alone.

Chapter 160 — Sarita’s Contribution

Threads of Four Colours: The Object-Structure of Autobiographical Labour

At the beginning of “Sarita’s Contribution,” Sarita uses threads of four colours to tie four separate bundles. Copies of philosophical pages, sources of examples, the expenses of time spent at the stove, receiving guests, and making copies, and receipts from the mobile camp at Simatirtha are all on one table but placed at a distance from one another. This carefully maintained distance is the chapter’s figure: the histories of different kinds of work must not be mixed together beneath one vague and sacred word, “contribution.” At the corner of the table sits Naira’s empty penholder, which Sarita does not touch. Through this absent object, the grief of the earlier Stri Parva enters the present examination of books, but Naira’s personal memory does not immediately become part of a public page. The narrator describes the breeze of a Chaitra morning and the slight movement of a washed sari. The living air of the household persists amid the lists of tasks.

In the second passage, the arrival of Maithili, Ishan, and Harimohan brings the work of writing books into a shared confrontation. From the first exchange, Sarita alters the question. It is not only “Where will my name be printed?” but “Who did which work, and when?” Maithili acknowledges the language of an earlier programme that called the contribution “help from the household,” but Sarita also halts the rush to assign a new status of co-author. Her resistance maintains an important continuity of character. Sarita, once wrongly declared dead and responsible for cooking in the earlier chapters, now determines the limits of her own work in the allocation of credit. She neither claims ownership of all the labour of life nor allows it to disappear into the misty category of “invaluable service.”

Ink on Pages and the Duration of Revision: Credit Among Several Voices

Harimohan’s work of comparison lends linguistic precision to the scene. A line of original argument is in Ishan’s handwriting; some clean copies are

in Sarita's hand; and certain answers changed after questions were raised bear the mark of Maithili's revision. Yet dates cannot be found for every alteration. Consequently, the narrative of authorship does not leap into a simple story of "one author, one injustice." Ishan says, "The philosophical answer is mine." Maithili refuses to omit the fact that the answer changed after a question. Sarita insists upon checking the time spent on each page. Although the third-person narrator remains externally positioned, each character's distinct language of claim is given room. This practical polyphony produces a denser narrative than a final proclamation of truth from one protagonist.

The old expenses for rice, oil, and lamp wicks in the third bundle form the chapter's most intimate sequence of objects. The smell of nights spent drying paper—wet pages, ash from the cooking fire, ink—survives in Sarita's memory. But smell alone cannot say which page was written on which date. The narrative significance lies not in declaring the "authenticity" of smell as evidence but in recognising that remembered time differs from written dates. Analepsis does not return as a fully enacted scene; olfactory memory descends upon the present table as a brief image. Sarita's recollections and Harimohan's documentary material enter into dialogue, while the narrator does not impose one character's experience upon the story of another.

"Not every meal in the house is a debt owed by the author" is an especially subtle sentence. If the demand to name domestic labour made every ordinary family meal proof of a book's origin, the characters' lives would become caught in a different kind of exaggeration. Sarita marks the days when extra food was prepared for visiting writers and keeps the days of ordinary life apart. This small separation establishes her not as an image of the self-sacrificing housewife but as a thoughtful woman who understands the actual limits of work. Nevertheless, the dialogue's brisk and highly organised classification can also repeat the author's preference for something resembling scholastic debate: every object is separated neatly in a register, while the prolonged difficulty of confused human memory receives somewhat less space.

Uma's Cooperative Labour and Mina's Field: Parallel to the Main Narrative, Not Identical to It

In passages seven through nine, the arrival of Uma Rajdhob opens an independent contemporary scene of work outside Sarita's recollections. Uma rejects a proposal to bill the collective washing work of four women solely in the name of an old contractor. She accepts a collective invoice but demands a separate page recording each member's labour and share. One member worked two fewer days because of illness. Her working days are

not falsely shown as equal, although her share in the common capital remains separate. This is not merely an example of the debate over authorial contribution: it has concrete economic consequences in Uma's loss of a customer and a new small order. An old customer refuses to renew the next contract, reducing the income. Sarita refuses to use the news about Uma as a "victory illustration" in her own book. The novel thereby displays an ethical-aesthetic self-awareness: the loss of one woman's livelihood must not become decorative evidence in another woman's intellectual struggle.

In passages thirteen to fifteen, the dispute over Mina Tharu's family agricultural lease returns in a different form. Father, mother, and daughter bring separate concerns about land, the danger posed by a canal, and the cost of medicines. Rather than accepting a long company lease, they choose to test an alternative agreement for limited cultivation. The company withdraws its offer to rent equipment, and the difficulty of financing treatment increases. The narrator prevents the easy transformation "rights protected = entire life improved." The family makes an independent choice, but it carries a financial cost. Uma's loss of a customer and Mina's loss of a company offer are different commercial events. To subsume them under one slogan of women's freedom would erase the particular stories of the characters. In the passage, Sarita does not seize the original contract without being asked, and Maithili does not immediately turn the event into a philosophical illustration. Such restraint deserves attention in criticism of the work's method.

Bela Turha's temporary move to a different market site supplies a third parallel experience of labour. The higher platform offers the advantage of less waterlogging, but it places customers farther away. Bela accepts the new location on three conditions: visible route markers, an adjustment of initial fees, and a safe corner for repairing nets. On the first day, three former customers fail to arrive and two new ones come. This mixed outcome is the narrative time of a living market. Her demand—"I accepted the new place, but I lost old customers; write both"—is more than a metaphor about paperwork. It is a distinctive closing statement from a businesswoman. Sarita does not make public the private ledger of Bela's outstanding customer debts. "Credit" thus becomes less the production of a flattering image than a rhythm of chosen rights to narration.

Translation at Simatirtha and the Currency of Labour: The Limits of Transmitted Speech

In the nineteenth and twentieth passages, an episode emerges concerning Mina Sarki's leatherwork sample and a cross-border partnership. In the

first trial, a strap loosened when wet and the sample was returned. New stitching and testing standards are now being developed. The narrator links this business scene with the work of the translator Kumudi. A translation that turns "shared rights" into "an outright sale of the design" alters the meaning, while the currency used for labour across the border is different. Mina asks to hear the line again before signing. Payment for the sample is approved; separate permission for use of the new design remains a future question. Kumudi's translator's wages are also due. At the narrative level, the episode matters because the choice of words constitutes an economic event. Here translation does not merely report an event that has already taken place; it changes the structure of what may happen next.

A needle-wounded palm, the loose knot of a leather strap, and the words spoken by Kumudi form a vivid sensory series. An abstract debate about language becomes connected to a bodily injury and the material of skilled work. Yet the novel's repeated pattern of "one wrong sentence" and "two separate rights" begins to grow predictable at this point. In every subplot, the movement from a sensible character to a swiftly separated payment line and then a future consent form can diminish the autonomy of narrative conflict. Despite this artistic objection, Mina Sarki's refusal to sign and the new testing of the strap are definite acts, not merely dialogue about principles.

From the Book's "Acknowledgments" to a Newly Published Page: The Outcome of the Main Action

In passages twenty-one through twenty-four, the story returns to the principal table. Ishan's new printing draft separates three days of copying, the unverified memory of a source, and a documented portion of domestic arrangements. Payment for household labour is nevertheless marked "recalculation pending." Harimohan prepares a preliminary source sheet divided into four categories and leaves a blank line for permission from people still omitted, such as an unnamed neighbour. Maithili accepts named acknowledgment of her contribution but does not treat it as a final determination of verified co-authorship. Ishan records a commitment to examine the sources. Consequently, the new page to be published at the school constitutes a preliminary correction, not the final judgment on the entire history. The old acknowledgments page will not be destroyed; readers who possess an old copy may ask for an amendment. The paratext of the novel—a book's multiple editions—thus becomes the subject of a narrative event.

The narrative significance is that the scene does not end with the words "the name has been added." The actual dues for Sarita's copying remain outstanding; verification of the original sources for examples remains to be

done; and the final decision on acknowledgment for Maithili's independent revisions remains unsettled. Ishan's old personal expense ledger contains an advance for food but no receipt for copying wages. Such incompletion preserves the characters' remaining future. In human relationships, recognition, financial accounting, and literary authorship are not resolved at one moment; the novel establishes them in different rhythms of action. This is also a long-delayed return of the disputes about teacher and pupil and credit for knowledge in Chapters 82–84. But the earlier incidents are not repeated word for word: the publication of a new page and the issue of remuneration carry them forward.

Naira's Penholder, Maithili's Blank Page, and the Final Four Bundles

In passages twenty-five and twenty-six, the presence of Kabir and Maithili draws the narrative back from the page of intellectual credit into private life. Kabir remembers the incomplete name of a neighbour of the woman who raised him. Sarita agrees to leave the space blank, while insisting that the person concerned must have an opportunity to respond if the name is discovered. Maithili asks Sarita not for permission to write her own independent name, but for acceptance within a shared relationship of life. Sarita replies that Maithili should write her name independently; Sarita's contribution should not become an introduction to Maithili's. Maithili does not turn this answer into a philosophical formula. She writes her name upon the first blank page of her notebook. This ending through action is visually powerful. Instead of an announcement of a name, there is writing by hand; instead of a slogan about autonomy, there is the filling of a blank page. That is where the story takes bodily form.

In the final passage, the four differently coloured bundles are closed again. The red public copy will go to the school, the household expense register will remain private, the camp's payment list will go to the officer, and the source list will be opened to review in accordance with permission. The colour-divided table of the opening has become a set of materials travelling in separate directions. Despite the numerous subplots in between, the correspondence of objects at beginning and end creates a strong composition. Naira's empty chair remains in its place; a new page in a book cannot change her death. The writer keeps achievements and losses in the story-world distinct. The closing sentence offers the possibility of Maithili's future independent page while promising, without declaring a future fully achieved, that Sarita's contribution will not become invisible again beneath someone else's voice.

Critical Outcome: The Achievement and Risk of Making Credit into a Story

The chapter's principal artistic achievement is to tell the story of authorial credit not merely as theory, but through the visible media of four coloured threads, the edges of ink on pages, oil receipts marked with turmeric, needle-stitching on a blanket, washed clothing, and a newly signed page. Instead of one protagonist gaining a right, there are scenes in which the different kinds of work performed by many workers are written down. Sarita determines her own question independently; Maithili does not distribute unconsidered credit in a rush of remorse; and Ishan acknowledges the work of others alongside the portion of philosophical argument that is his own. The chief weakness is the excessively segmented sequence of events. A single chapter contains book pages, cooperative washing, an agricultural lease, a fish market, cross-border leatherwork, and school publication, repeatedly interrupting the emotional climax. Moreover, nearly all characters quickly express fine conceptual distinctions, leaving less space for the inarticulate speech and uncertain feelings of ordinary life. Nevertheless, the silence of Naira's empty penholder, Sarita's memory of the lamp's smell, and Maithili writing her name upon the first blank page counterbalance this elaborate design with profound human experience.

Ashvamedha Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 157–160

From a Fixed Window to a Moving Road: The Expansion of the Parva's Chronotope

At the end of Anushasana Parva, in "The Exception to the Rule," the local counter and the fixed geography of the settlement were especially important. The first four chapters of Ashvamedha Parva carry that counter outward to the wheels of a vehicle, the hooves of a horse, the steps of a bus, and the entrance to different villages. Chapter 157 parallels the royal horse with a modern vehicle; 158 places the father-son relationship in Manipura beside Kabir's history of foster care; 159 follows a travelling camp in Chaitra; and 160 sends its four bundles in different directions. These are not the same events, but they share the travelling question, "Whose permission, whose name, whose labour?" Against the universal mobility of the epic Ashvamedha, access in the modern narrative depends upon separate permission in each village. Treating the two as one system of government would destroy the central subtlety of the narrative's metaphor.

The contemporary narrative strand moves from the last week of Phagun in 2040 into Chaitra (157, 159–160). The intervening modern episodes belong to spring; the ancient narrative is plainly a separate historical-imaginative time stream. Both the beginning and ending of Chapter 157 are constructed through alternation between the two periods. Chapter 158 likewise edits from ancient Manipura to the modern shelter, then back to Manipura and again to the shelter. Chapters 159–160 contain no independent ancient scenes. Instead, memories of the past and recurrences of earlier incidents in the novel are absorbed into present experience. The mechanical indication of a "two-period intertext" in the earlier narrative needs to be read in accordance with these real differences. In particular, the journey of the bus in Chapter 159 is the full scenic development of the initial modern proposal in 157.

Four Different Combinations of Narrative Time, Duration, and Frequency

Chapter 157 passes over the journey through the first two villages in brief summary, while the field boundary and bridge dispute in the third village receive an extended scene. In 158, arrival at Manipura's palace gate, two or three moments of archery practice, trembling, and the public document are held within a condensed account of the long absence between father and son. In 159, the successive duration of a bus journey from morning to night moves the story forward, while days of unpaid earlier labour and dates of future camp meetings repeatedly extend its present. In 160, a meeting about a book lasting from dawn to night brings memories of numerous earlier incidents to one table. Through these different temporal arrangements, the rhythm of the work gradually moves from the epic mobility of its opening toward the smaller, denser, more personal time of Sarita's domestic objects.

The recurrence of objects also produces changing meanings. In 157, the reins of the royal horse and the ropes of the modern vehicle indicate the limits of control. In 158, a severed bowstring, a fragment of an arrow, and a stitched blanket become memories of relationships broken and joined. In 159, a receipt book initially empty fills by day's end with the signatures of many people. In 160, coloured bundles become distinct narrative levels for different kinds of work. Naira's empty chair recurs in varying contexts across Chapters 158, 159, and 160. The object keeps the personal duration of mourning separate from the communal clock of public progress; excessive repetition, however, could diminish the image's spontaneous emotional force.

Characters' Voices and the Problem of a Public Rhythm

Draupadi, Chitrangada, Ulupi, Rama, Ruhani, Kumudi, Ramvati, Sharda, Uma, Durga, Mina, Bela, Sarita, and Maithili: numerous women assume influential, decisive roles across these four chapters. Merely counting voices, however, does not suffice to establish polyphony. The substantive differences lie in what they do. Draupadi adds a line for labour along the road; Chitrangada speaks for the years of daily governance in her kingdom; Ulupi preserves her right to private grief; Ramvati wants to carry the days of old rice-transplanting labour into her new location; Sharda corrects a mistake in her own business; and Sarita identifies the exact work concealed under the word "help" in a book. The novel's polyphony becomes useful only if each of these events remains distinct.

The artistic limitation of this polyphony is complex. Many characters state correct distinctions with extraordinary clarity, while administrative or military opponents quickly voice comparatively simplified, mistaken positions. The outcome of a debate can therefore be anticipated. Pairs such as translation and wages, public and private copies, entry and ownership, birth and upbringing, revision and authorship repeatedly appear as opposed terms in a discussion. The novel's vivid moments—the roughness of reins, Babhruvahana's trembling platter, Ramvati's beaten rice, the old woman's bangle, Kabir's blanket, and Sarita's turmeric-marked receipt—restore a more human uncertainty and the resistance of material things to these over-explicit dialogues.

The Outcomes of Four Chapters and the Reader's Next Expectation

In 157, the horse receives a limited route rather than an undisputed acknowledgment of universal royal authority; the modern team gains a meeting in one village, not collective consent from all villages. In 158, Arjuna recognises Babhruvahana's living presence and the boundaries of a local kingdom, yet the injury caused by a long absence is not erased in one scene. Kabir discovers a path toward the history of his upbringing, not a complete answer about birth. In 159, separate receipts are created for many applicants, while questions of wages, land boundaries, the principal of a pawned debt, and administrative expenses remain. In 160, Sarita's name and work appear on a newly published page of preliminary correction, but her full wages and the final determination of co-authorship are still outstanding. This incompletion replaces the conventional epic expectation of "rights after victory" with the extended time of responsibility.

The independent page on which a name was written in the twenty-fourth through twenty-sixth passages is an actual narrative foreshadowing of Chapter 161, "Maithili's Own Name." Rather than the final cry of triumph at some grand undertaking, the sight of a name written in one's own hand

upon a page supplies the critical essence of the opening of Ashvamedha Parva. The achievement of these four chapters is to provide space for different lives, times, and relationships within epic mobility. The limitations are equally clear: a uniform procedural dialogue, rapid moral self-correction, and the density of numerous subplots. This duality enables the reader to encounter the new parva not as a theory's complete victory but as a multi-character narrative continually being made and revised.

Chapter 161 — Maithili's Own Name

Three Dots on an Old Proof: How the Narrative of Credit Begins

The chapter begins with the slanting light of morning, a yellowed proof sheet, and three ink dots on its right-hand side. To Ishan, the dots are printing marks; in Maithili's recollection they are marks she made to keep three possible answers distinct. These two readings of the same object draw the reader, without an extended preface, into the dispute over who wrote the text and whose questions changed its composition. The narrator discloses Maithili's recollection at the outset, so the mystery concerns the practical verification of credit rather than the detection of a culprit. The press's old register, three proofs, receipt stamps, and differences in handwriting arrive together on the table, but they do not all become evidence of equal weight.

The dramatic centre of the first eight passages is Maithili's assertion of her intellectual identity. She does not claim as her own the answers Ishan wrote. Instead, she takes her questions, alternative sequences of reasoning, and intellectually constructed objections out of the category of domestic advice. This careful delimitation prevents the conflict from becoming a simple story of opposition between wife and husband. The narrator reports Ishan's inward discomfort as early as passage two; the scene in which he slowly reads her reply comes in passage twenty-four. The interval in which his conduct changes lends credibility to the transformation, although the early disclosure of his inward state leaves somewhat less room for the reader's own inferences.

Branching Action: Printing Press, Driver, Seller, and Landing

Before midday, the story ceases to remain within the printing press. Haricharan's vehicle hire is separated from the driver's night wages, while the dispute over waiting time survives. Lakshmi Kathbaniya's old joint debt is removed from the public noticeboard, although the price owed for goods remains outstanding. Lakhan Satar's oral testimony about his shift, the receipt for tools, and the contractor's invoice are kept apart, and payment of undisputed wages is recommended. Vinita Kesharwani's

personal borrowing is distinguished from shared household purchases, so the household emerges not as a single financial agent but as a space of multiple rights. These four episodes are not merely a simultaneous social survey: each establishes a narrative relation to the central dispute over co-authorship.

The four branches do not, however, produce identical outcomes. Haricharan has a payment order but no confirmation of a bank deposit; Lakshmi obtains a correction of the notice that publicly defamed her but not payment for her supply; recognition of Lakhan's undisputed hours is recommended, while risk allowance remains undecided; Vinita pays one instalment, leaving the remaining joint dispute distinct. The final news report gathers these unequal outcomes together once more. Through this return, the branched narrative avoids dispersal, though the density of names and accounting categories places considerable demands on the reader's memory.

Focalisation and the Autonomy of Voices

The predominant focalisation remains close to Maithili's experience at the press, but the narrator gives separate scenic space to Sarita's inner discipline, Ishan's hesitation, and the demands of Lakhan and Vinita. Sarita resists turning an example from the marketplace she witnessed into Maithili's intellectual property. Lakhan says plainly that what he wants is wages, not a book explaining his name. Maithili accepts the distinction and decides not to print his name without permission. Here a secondary character refuses to become an illustration of the principal character's ideas. This is a genuine test of polyphony.

The male family member's argument about 'trust' and Vinita's answer concerning her right to sign are both heard, although the narrator's sympathies clearly lie with Vinita's decision. Lakshmi's insistence that a false charge be withdrawn, rather than that her debt be forgiven, offers a third form of the right to one's name within the narrative's language. Their different occupations and social relationships lend the voices some individuality. Yet there is also a risk that everyone's dialogue will be converted into an exceptionally orderly argument.

The Organisation of Time, Material Objects, and Final Decision

Within a single day's movement from morning to night, the proof sheet repeatedly returns. From the opening three dots to the complete sequence of signatures on the final correction notice, paper remains the stable centre of narration. The time occupied by subsidiary activities during the day passes in compressed narration; the conversation between Ishan and Maithili, the examination of the old binding, and the first signatures

expand into scenes. Maithili signs first, Ishan second, and Harimohan third. Sarita is not unnecessarily made to sign. This subtle ordering accomplishes the principal change in the plot without a grand proclamation of victory.

The chapter ends not by tearing up the old cover but by inserting a correction sheet inside it. Keeping earlier misattribution visible, rather than erasing it, alters the structure of the reader's memory. When Ishan asks what will change between the two of them, Maithili keeps the answer about public correction distinct from the answer about their domestic relationship. In the final passage, Naira's empty chair suddenly changes the terms of the scene: an earned moment of correct attribution is no universal solution to the absence created by death. By placing the next chapter's title, 'The Knower', on the page, the narrator leaves the question of intellectual authority open.

Critical Outcome

The chapter's notable achievement is to give material form to the question of ownership through proofs, margins, stamps, an ordered sequence of signatures, and the real expense of circulating a correction. Its formal limitation is that the connection among many subsidiary stories is explained directly through the formula of whose right belongs under whose name; some scenes could have afforded readers greater opportunity to discover those comparisons independently. Nevertheless, the claim to a woman's intellectual agency is achieved not by denying Ishan's writing but by establishing the limits of what the evidence shows she contributed. This demanding restraint gives the chapter its narrative distinctiveness.

Chapter 162 — The Claim of the Knower

An Unexpected Convergence of Two Times: From Blurred Letters to a Travelling Market

In the first eight passages, palm leaves, a peacock feather, metal type, and a third, older copy bring Udayana's philosophical disputation into view. The old woman copyist's warning, 'Do not read what has been rubbed out as a clear letter', is not mere instruction: she specifies the date of her copy and the limits of her testimony. In the dispute over whether a pot contains cool water or sand, opening its lid reveals that both partial accounts are true together. The novelist uses a visible test to set beside the competing claims to authority, without turning Udayana into an infallible adjudicator. The decision to leave a gap in the damaged text empty is a complete, but limited, outcome of the opening sequence.

The ninth passage's phrase 'in Chaitra of 2040, at a much later time' constitutes an explicit leap across historical time. The narration moves from an ancient veranda to the vehicle of a modern travelling camp through direct scenic editing, not through a character's dream or quotation. It would be wrong to read this transition as asserting a direct chain of historical causation. It is a narrative resonance between two different times concerning the authority to know, the ownership of labour, and the examination of another person's account. The opening scene must be read as a reconstructed episode within the novel, not as proof of the whole history of a philosophical tradition.

The Design of the Modern Branches: Many Dues Within One Market

Saroj Kharkaut's net is analysed into thread, stitching labour, capital, and the risk of hauling it; Sonmati Turi apportions responsibility for sample, colour, and transport. Niru Kumal proposes a limited consignment, separate quality inspection, and recognition of an apprentice girl's name against a jointly incurred kiln debt. In these three occupational scenes, the finished appearance of an object enables the reader to see the time concealed within its production. A knot in a net, a bamboo frame, and three uneven vessels show how a single name attached to finished goods can obscure distinct stages of work.

These simultaneous episodes have unequal results. A rule for sharing the cost of Saroj's net is established, but the capital has not actually been received; Sonmati will not sign without two copies of the advance and order; Niru agrees to a small partnership, while the apprentice's future share is still undecided. The story consequently avoids the implausible completeness of 'every right was secured in a day'. The episode of Kamlesh Khatik's red strip turns from the attribution of collective guilt toward testimony concerning an individual sale. The public accusation against the group is withdrawn, but a separate claim for economic loss survives.

Pace and Discrepancy: A Hearing Date Is Not a Settlement

In the case of Mangri Gorait's closed factory and its seven workers, attendance is provisionally confirmed for four, while documents are requested for the remaining three. A date has been given for a hearing, not money: Mangri's repeated insistence on this distinction marks a poignant difference in narrative time. Whenever the administrative cycle tries to close a file, the living time of the claim demands another beginning. Sona Kathautiya's stopping place, 'Berhi', is used only as a name on a transport receipt; the narrative provides no warrant for identifying it as an unknown confluence and drawing a map. Nahid Moghal's memory of the 'Livari' field and the proposed mortgage similarly concern personal consent, not proof of a precisely established land boundary.

These scenes pack an extraordinary number of disputes into a single market day. The narrator gives each group two or three passages, creating social breadth, but leaving Mangri's household and Nahid's family psychology less fully explored than they might be. The action of ending her brother's telephone call, in particular, creates a tension of silence stronger than the clarity of argument. That brief opening allows the reader to imagine what form Nahid's future resistance might take.

Plural Focalisation and the Narrative Form of Thought

Udayana's gathering opens with a dispute about admission, in which the right to be heard is distinguished from the truth of an argument. In the modern market, Saroj, Sonmati, Niru, Kamlesh, Mangri, and Nahid each recount their own experience, while Rama refuses to mark mutually different outcomes as 'completed' together. Polyphony is not simply a count of how many people speak. Kamlesh's witness recognises the distinction between 'seeing the strip' and 'seeing the seller'; Niru's apprentice can raise a claim to her own name; Mangri requires the administration to change the words of its reply. Nevertheless, the speeches of these voices tend to reach similarly clear decision-formulas, partially levelling their individual rhythms of speech.

Circular Closure: Deleting the Word 'Infallible'

In passages twenty-seven through twenty-nine, the story returns to the printing press. Ishan asks whether he should write 'my decision is final'; Maithili protects both recognition of co-authorship and the right to test the arguments. Ishan strikes 'infallible' from the draft. At the beginning, Udayana had refused to accept his name as evidence for a rubbed-out letter; at the end, Ishan corrects his mistake of treating his own name as the stamp of an unchallengeable judgment. This parallel between opening and conclusion works artistically, although there is no actual contact between characters across the two historical time strands.

The chapter's finest image is the knot in the net: a knot in the written sheet, another joining labour and capital, and the difficulty of untying the language of a new preface. Its limitation is that the final remark about 'recognising the right hand' explains the meaning of the comparison once again. The scenes are sufficiently strong that leaving part of this significance unspoken could have allowed the suggestion, or dhvani, to resonate more openly.

Chapter 163 — An Old Book, a New Preface

Deleting 'Complete': The Extended Time of Revision

The half-dried proof beside Harimohan's window and the old cover sliding over the new preface give the chapter a strikingly objective opening. Ishan's name alone on the old cover, Maithili's omitted contribution inside: the distinction between the book's exterior and interior becomes visible upon a single table. Ishan strikes 'complete' from the earlier preface. In its place come separate registers of his original writing, Maithili's verified co-authorship, Sarita's labour, and the questions that remain unresolved. The narrative aim here is not to repeat the previous chapter's decision but to display the difficult duration between accepting that decision and conveying it to readers.

The apprentice girl's question at the press markedly extends story time towards the future. Once old copies have scattered, immediate acceptance cannot transform what every future reader knows. An incomplete address register, village names without post offices, the cost of distribution, and free correction sheets accompanying old copies make the uncertainty of future reading part of a present decision. Ishan's personal remuneration and the publisher's public duty to distribute the correction are recorded separately. Sarita's wages are not a fund from which to meet this expense.

The Principal Sequence and the Difference Between Kinds of Work: Sarita's Presence

Sarita arrives at the press and counts her outstanding days of copying before accepting thanks. Signatures for two of her days remain missing, so she signs only the entries she recognises. The narrative effect concerns unequal rhythms of time even more than the authenticity of a statement. An author's preface can be corrected in a day, but the administrative clock of wages and dues moves differently. The act of taking Naira's old paper from a bag and putting it back without showing it prevents grief from becoming part of a public celebration. Maithili, too, makes no grand speech at this point: silence becomes a form of respect for the distance between their experiences.

A Sequence of Scenes: From the Fish Market to Resettlement Land

Vinod Kewart's fish-market dispute raises the question of equal access to shade for small vendors and exemptions granted to a contractor. A provision for temporary facilities enters the order, but adjustment of past collections remains pending, as does the question whether his daughter has actually received a shaded place. Sona Kathautiya secures an order concerning her hire charges but no deposit confirmation. A photograph of

a donation is kept distinct from the dues owed for transport labour. In both cases, the distance between written assurances and tangible benefits received stays alive.

The proposal to give Phulchan Lodh a remote plot equal in area is a significant narrative counterargument. Farming, irrigation, and access to the market are decisive for the father; the son hopes for a house sooner. Their disagreement resists the easy tendency to give an affected family a single voice. An on-site inspection is arranged, but the price of delay may be an entire season in temporary shelter. Lakshmi Jhangar receives a copy of an old contract, not verified recovery of wages. Her brother's exhausted dissent and the gesture of securing the string of a bag create an emotional interval.

Tulsi Donwar's rights in two villages and Badri Nonfar's old field document bring back the complexity of concrete geography. Names such as 'Burhanad' and 'Balthi' serve as references to sources within the story; they do not automatically constitute verified cartography. Characters can agree with one another without surrendering the differences among their claims. This sequence relates the problem of 'one name equals the whole authorship' in a book to the reductive formula 'one name equals one right' in land matters. Yet the procedures for investigating the two problems remain different.

The Voice of the New Preface: Correcting the Self-Admiring Narrator

Old descriptions of ancient disputation—'defeated opponent', 'infallible conclusion', and 'unbroken tradition'—finally yield to language open to revision. This is more than an ideological verdict. Ishan records variant readings in sources; Maithili warns that 'assistance' may obscure co-authorship; Harimohan opens the verified copy of the title page. Replacing 'pure and flawless' with 'open to revision' remakes the book's relationship with its readers. The narrator partly represents Ishan's inward change through observable actions. The recurring act of deleting old words becomes the principal device through which his authorial voice is reconstructed.

The Doorway in the Last Page: Urmila's Envelope

In passage twenty-eight, Vinod's daughter says that the name has been written down, but the place in the shade still has to be seen. This line sets a limit to Maithili's progress in having her name printed without diminishing that progress. Passage twenty-nine turns the story towards another task when, on the next morning, an old slip recording clothes-washing wages owed to Urmila's family is found. Separating the printing-house bundle from Urmila's envelope is another act of material editing: an

object that closes one chapter prepares to become the opening scene of the next.

The chapter's achievement lies in looking beyond the conclusion of revision to its life in distribution. Its limitation is that various accounts of dues often follow the same discriminating pattern: order versus receipt, name versus work, memory versus location. This repetition creates discipline, but the full emotional worlds of particular characters often remain compressed. Even so, the disagreement between Phulchan and his son, the weariness of Lakshmi's brother, and Sarita's silence prevent the narrative from shrinking entirely into one formula for decision.

Chapter 164 — What Is Owed to Urmila

From the Envelope's String to the Empty Place at the Washing Landing

The envelope at the end of Chapter 163 returns as the first scene of Chapter 164. Sarita separately counts the copy of an application, a receipt for clothes at the landing, and a record of the hospital night shift inside it. The first two passages establish a boundary: Urmila's outstanding dues must not be merged with the correction sheet from the press. Sunlight falling on the washing platform and the empty place allotted to Urmila keep death from becoming abstract mourning. The three colours of string around the bundles, their names, days, and remembered labour give the vacant place a social dimension. The material distinction among three colours resonates with Sarita's bundles in earlier chapters without effacing the specificity of Urmila's own work.

Urmila's sister stops her pen at the expression 'representative of the deceased'. She is Urmila's sister and the representative accepted by the family, but Urmila herself cannot be absorbed into her. Through this linguistic correction, a designation under succession is not allowed to become a full substitute for someone's life. At the meeting, the fact that the family received assistance is invoked as though it answered the wage claim. Rama closes the relief register and opens the register of dues. This small change of paper is a scenic turning point: instead of the last line of one official account, another account begins.

The Multiple Stages of a Decision and the Stretching of Story Time

Urmila's night shift, the washing of two bundles, transport charges, a customer's sheet, and family relief are separate matters, so the chapter cannot close them within a single event called 'payment'. Attendance is first checked against Uma's limited recollection and the customer's signature; an order for undisputed wages follows. At the sister's objection,

'final settlement' is removed. In passage ten there is an order but no deposit; by passage thirty the bank confirms a partial deposit for two bundles. These twenty intervening passages stretch the narrative's duration through waiting and other lives proceeding in parallel.

When the contractor tries to treat work already performed as unpaid 'voluntary service' during a disaster, the sister asks about the time and rate agreed beforehand. The narrative does not make her an unqualified victor: a dispute over half a shift, transport, and the return of the customer's property remains. She keeps the original sheet safe in her bag and makes no victorious declaration even after receiving the bank's deposit confirmation. In this restraint, the narrative of economic action does not take the place of the narrative of grief, nor the reverse.

A Branching World of Labour: Distinct Lives Rather Than Representative Cases

The middle part forms five separate narrative units around Kiran Raut's sharecropper debt, Phulmati Tiyar's new net-making group, Kedar Bauri's migrant workers, Shiv Dhandi's spelling of his name, and Noorjahan Itfarosh's care of an animal. Kiran's wrongly compounded interest is reduced, though the original seed debt remains. Phulmati chooses conditions for a limited new consignment rather than remaining under the former name. One member of Kedar's group receives money; another's payment is held up by an account-number error. Shiv receives confirmation of arrears deposited, but damage caused by delay remains a claim. Noorjahan's undisputed transport dues are accepted, while treatment of the donkey is still unresolved. These precise differences must be stated if the middle section is not to seem a mere parade of examples.

The rent of Phulwa's house and the timing of bank-deposit messages join the public register of labour to private domestic time. Shiv's delayed pay, caused by two spellings of his name, is not a replica of someone else's dispute but an event produced by a linguistic error of its own. A crack in Noorjahan's donkey's hoof and unequal disputes over its safe transport route and treatment expenses extend the means of labour to the body of a living animal. Read attentively, such material images are not only evidentiary instruments; they create a sense of distinct lived worlds.

Sarita's Silence and the Sister's Silence: Unequal Forms of Grief

In passages twenty-three and twenty-four the story reaches its deepest emotional pause. Sarita cannot bring herself to open Naira's locked drawer; Urmila's sister must open the laundry ledger, because otherwise no one will acknowledge the dead woman's wages. Deaths in the same year bring the two women close, but the narrator makes clear that their lives and work

were different. The moment in which the sister shows Sarita a piece of string and then returns it to her own bag is especially valuable: memory does not become the property of a public file. Through this silence, the reader's feeling of mourning grows from different incapacities and actions rather than from speeches.

Later, Uma ensures that her current municipal wages are kept separate from Urmila's family's claim. The story refuses to combine the remembrance of a dead woman's work and the present remuneration of a living woman into one inheritance. At this point, the sister's voice does not claim exclusive authority over everyone else's labour. She represents the family's claim, not the ownership of other women's work in the present.

River Names and a Severed Sentence: Two Forms of Foreshadowing

Nandini's water register for 'Puraini' and Tulsi's spelling 'Balan/Bhutahi Balan' are not taken as verified geographical determinations. The distinction among a receipt for an object, vehicle hire, customary family rights of use, and a river's actual boundaries remains part of the narrative. In passages twenty-eight and twenty-nine, a water-stained original ledger and an altered numeral on a clean copy create fresh documentary uncertainty; the stain alone, however, does not identify an offender. In passage thirty-two, a half-printed statement about 'closing an account after death' clearly foreshadows another dispute. The reader knows that an omission occurred but does not yet know the whole original sentence or who sent it.

In the final passage the sister places the death certificate, partial bank confirmation, the outstanding claim, and Urmila's own string in four separate places. Water on the veranda erases her footprint, while the deposit and remaining dues stay written. The opposition between a fleeting bodily mark and a relatively durable record is not a simple emblem of 'paper is always true'. The paper preserves the unsettled dues just as faithfully as it marks how incomplete the settlement is.

Overall Critical Judgment

The sister's unmistakable voice, the empty washing platform, and the silent moment of bank confirmation give the chapter its centre. A particular strength is that, even after numerous stories of other workers, the last scene returns to the sister going home and drying clothes. Its limitation is that five or seven small disputes in the middle follow a repeatedly similar pattern of abbreviated resolution. Urmila's intimate life is encountered through other people's memories of objects, rather than through an extended flashback. Nevertheless, resisting the conversion of death into an all-encompassing relief narrative and safeguarding the

separate working time of living and deceased women constitute the chapter's firm narratological achievement.

Ashvamedha Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 161–164

The Narrative Bridge Across Four Chapters

The proof sheet of 161 and the evidence for the phrase 'co-author: Maithili' become, in 162, a conflict across historical time between prestige and the testing of statements. Chapter 163 opens the long social time of printing correct credit and getting that correction into the hands of earlier readers. Urmila's envelope at the end of 163 becomes the centre of the opening of 164. Thus the sequence 'the name of a right → the limits of recognition → circulation of a correction → the outstanding labour of the dead' binds the chapters together. These are not four versions of one event: each link turns an unfinished question into the beginning of another scene.

A Joint Examination of Time, Scene Density, and Focalisation

Chapters 161, 163, and 164 follow a morning-to-night progression made up of office visits and several hearings branching across a single day. In 162, an overt break in time separates ancient philosophical disputation from a travelling camp in Chaitra 2040. Foreshadowing across the four chapters is chiefly carried by objects: the 'knower' page in 161, the wording of the preface in 162, Urmila's envelope in 163, and the severed message in 164. The narrator knows the inner condition of many characters but does not remain at one fixed viewpoint. Narrative proximity shifts among the distinct scenes at the printing press, marketplace, landing, hospital meeting, and home.

Objects, Voices, and Undecided Outcomes

The ink on the proof, blurred palm-leaf letters, a knot in a net, the old cover, laundry string, and a bank message matter because they show the reader different times for 'who said', 'who worked', and 'who received'. Yet the characters' voices do not form a single ideological consensus. The disagreement of Phulchan's son, Mangri's weariness with hearings, the differing grief of Urmila's sister and Sarita, and the question posed by Lakshmi's brother open distinct emotional registers. The chief formal risk is the well-ordered comparative syntax used for too many cases. At some points the novelist states outright the significance the reader might have been allowed to infer.

Expectations for the Next Chapter

The original context of the half-sentence at the end of Chapter 164 remains open for the next narrative. To declare its meaning with certainty here would exceed the limits of the reader's knowledge. The relevant questions for the sequence ahead are who excised the quoted words, when the reader or characters will obtain their complete form, and which actions genuinely change as a result. This second four-chapter unit of Ashvamedha Parva achieves not a final conclusion but a coherent intermediate stopping point.

Chapter 165 — The Import of a Sentence

The Missing 'Only': The Narrative Force of an Incomplete Sentence

The severed sentence at the end of Chapter 164 becomes the very object of inquiry at the opening of the next chapter. On the school's veranda, Padma spreads out two copies: an incomplete message circulated publicly and a certified letter obtained from the municipal accounts section. Wind lifting the paper keeps the scene in motion; the stones holding the sheets in place make the bodily work of reading visible. The mystery moves beyond the general possibility that someone changed something and centres on a particular linguistic operation. The removal of the word 'only' and what followed it makes the limited closure of a relief grant appear to be the settlement of all payments for services. The complete letter says that closing the account for immediate relief does not preclude examination of certified dues for washing, transport, and other work. In contrast, the truncated statement makes Urmila's outstanding earnings disappear. Manipulation of meaning thereby becomes a real economic risk within the story-world, not a mere curiosity of linguistics.

Padma's order of reading—the main line, annexure, issue number, margin, and reverse of the page—slows narrative speed. Against the rapid effect of the printed allegation, reconstructing the text is a patient procedure involving several sheets. The movement from the veranda to the municipality and then the washing landing creates three levels of inquiry: the textual original, institutional issuance, and the person whose life the text affected. The sister's question, 'Will this sentence put the money into the account?', is the decisive rejoinder of the story. Sarita's 'No' immediately checks an anticipated happy ending. The full sentence may be published, but the outstanding wages have still not arrived.

Circulating the Correction, Limited Publication, and the Unknown Cutter

The absence of the number of a circular stamp stating 'family consent' from the original dispatch register opens another line of mystery. Yet Rama does not instantly declare anyone guilty on seeing an imitation stamp: she keeps the paper, the distributors, and the times of receipt in separate evidentiary sequences. On Sarita's phone, the original sender and the person who forwarded the message to a later group turn out to be different. The narrator does not thereby promise to unveil a concealed criminal. The drama arises instead from the layered process of communication. Rather than burning the old truncated notice to 'erase' it, the characters paste a public correction beside it. Readers see the first error and its correction together; the narrative does not delete a past mistake in the name of revised history.

At the same time, the boundary of privacy is redrawn. Padma makes available the letter number, date, issuing section, and public wording, while withholding bank digits, the home address, and any image of Urmila's private piece of string. This distinction serves a serious narrative purpose: the 'whole sentence' is not synonymous with an 'entire private file'. Rama keeps the designated institutional route open for verification. The correction's practical achievement is measured when Urmila's sister herself reads the sentence on the public noticeboard and returns with the date for examining the remaining shifts. An unclear vehicle number related to transport is still disputed. Awareness of unpaid dues restrains the reader's relief.

Many Accounts in One Day: The Distribution of Scenes and Character Voices

The middle of the chapter extends from Nasim Idrisi's sewing order to Kamla Thakur's mortgaged bracelet, Nahid Moghal's conditional mortgage, Sugni Saday's resettlement, and Geeta Kori's cross-border clothing dues. These are not different branches of a single cause arising from Urmila's death; they are independent struggles dispersed among veranda, shop, neighbourhood, and market. Nasim keeps five coloured bags distinct from a private measurement ledger. A confidential receipt number enables the work materials and wage accounts to remain traceable without publicising private details. In Kamla's case the elderly woman's ownership of her bracelet is acknowledged, but the fee for redeeming the pledge and the dispute over family debt remain. Nahid, though afraid, chooses risk attached to a limited share rather than either complete refusal or unconditional acceptance. Characters thus bear responsibility for

practical alternatives rather than becoming moral figures who always say 'yes' or always say 'no'.

Sugni's string and the neighbourhood's new list shift the story towards a crisis of representation. Consent to emergency evacuation is not consent to permanent resettlement, and the living conditions of three families are presented separately. The narrator also acknowledges that this decision may increase pressure on the limited water-vehicle supply and the delays of temporary arrangements. Geeta sees a partial payment for an undisputed clothing consignment deposited in her bank, but refuses to sign a receipt saying 'all dues finally settled'. Durga Gangai's new sale and Suraj Gangota's old debt occur in the same sunlight without becoming causes of one another's stories. The resulting collection of scenes is a broad social narrative, not the omnipotent victory tale of a single protagonist.

Returning Objects, Narrative Duration, and Formal Limitations

The principal action extends from one morning to evening. Examination of the letter, public reading, hearings, a bank message, and the return to the noticeboard repeatedly arrest the passage of time. The narrator pauses in turn near Padma, Sarita, the sister, Nasim, Kamla, Nahid, Sugni, and Geeta; no one consciousness permanently governs the entire scene. Paper trembling in the wind, a sewing stitch, the crooked flower on a bracelet, evacuation string, and a loom's thread gain meaning through the particular lives to which they belong. Even at the last scene, the pin holding a paper does not provide automatic justice. It holds only through the continuing labour of people willing to read and question the text.

Here, too, lies the formal limitation. In nearly every branch there is another explanation of falsely closed paperwork, a conditional signature, and a claim that remains pending. At times, dialogue sounds more like an ideal statement of method than like natural hesitation. The scenes are brief enough to leave little space for a particular character's long silence, sudden emotion, or mistaken decision. Yet Geeta's genuinely received partial bank payment, the material costs of Sugni's decision, and the sister's continuing unpaid wages resist the formula. The chapter's distinctive result is that the reader understands that a truncated sentence can be restored while the working time lost through that truncation cannot simply be returned.

Chapter 166 — The Weaver's Market

The Wet Board at the Cattle Shed: Objects, Smell, and the Market Scene

On a Bhadau morning, the transparent board at Sukathi's cattle shed carries water from fish baskets rather than dew. Vinod Kewart raises a plank to make the slippery passage safer, just as Yusuf Ansari arrives with two lengths of cloth bordered in red and yellow and a grey sample. The opening is dense with distinct smells, colours, water, and the feel of timber. Geeta Kori's concern in the previous chapter is active from the very first sentence here: the labour account must be opened before the goods are sold. The market is a dramatic stage but not merely a backdrop. Wet cloth, a sagging plank, blocked drainage, and waiting customers alter the course of action.

A brief analepsis supplies Yusuf's earlier experience. The distinction between an unidentified consignment carrying an invalid acceptance label in the hospital's name and his lawful goods had already been recorded. But the delay stopped his yarn, the date for his son's training fee passed, and his standing in the market was damaged. This is why the correction of ownership is no decorative certificate of honour but a fragile opportunity to resume trading. The narrator does not claim that the source of the unidentified consignment has been fully investigated. At the chapter's end, the committee merely withdraws collective blame from Yusuf's legitimate cloth.

Six Columns and a Seventh Withheld Amount: The Multiple Agents of Labour

Parvati Tanti's refusal to accept the formula 'profits half and half' without further examination is the first decisive turn. The warp-setting and tying work of two other women in her home, ownership of the loom, yarn, dye, damage to spoiled fabric, and the sale itself cannot all be contained within Yusuf's easy word 'half'. Pavitra Patwa objects to merging her knotting rate into the weaving rate. Geeta has six columns written down—yarn, dye, weaving, knotting, transport, and selling—plus a seventh labelled 'money withheld'. She does not, however, shift an old company's unpaid amount to a new customer. The main beauty of the chapter's organisation lies in this distinction: producing goods together and appropriating someone else's history of labour are different acts.

Sakina Rangrez is prepared to accept responsibility for her own earlier faulty dyeing but will not let it cancel a customer's debt from another consignment. Inspection of dye samples, protection of the confidential

customer's identity, and the disposal of leftover dye into the cattle-shed drain make dyeing more than a description of craft skill. Similarly, Usha Ram's sample design is contractually distinguished as a price for one consignment rather than an assignment of rights to all future production. Her craft does not bind her to an inherited occupational identity; the possibility of an initial advance for training also opens. Parvati, Pavitra, and Usha agree only to a trial of making a new product together. Successful sale of that product has not yet occurred in the story.

Separate Stories of Small Businesses and the Unequal Times of Bargaining

Vinod's old dispute over a wholesale vehicle occupying shade in the fish market, Phulmati's division of capital for nets, Hira's standardised water measures, Chandrika's work gathering and opening makhana, and wages for singing create different times of production within one market. An independent receipt is issued for the first small sale, but the old contractor's collections remain unsettled. Offering food at a musical performance does not automatically constitute the wages owed for performing. Bindeshwari Sahu's sale of an oil press follows another temporal line: the ancestral signboard and weights are kept safe while an inventory is prepared for the machine that can be sold. A sale at a reduced price and the direction of repayment of old wage debts are determined.

Devki Pal's temporary decision to move a tent away from the livestock path and Kiran Raut's refusal to treat the old word 'Adhwara' as a map of current drainage introduce geography into these many voices. That name remains in the old documents of the story-world; it is not automatically presented as a mapped contemporary place. The market committee repeatedly wants an immediate decision, but customer testing, a farmer's season, a company's arrears, and the time dye takes to dry demand different durations. Compressing such different rhythms into one market day is at once the achievement and the risk of the narration.

Fault Was Not Yet Established: Testing Delay and Actual Payment

When the displayed cloth is found wet, Sakina does not immediately admit fault. She asks for time to dry and test the sample. Yusuf obtains a day's extension from the buyer, who in return reduces the advance. This moment deepens the chapter's ethical complexity: caution has a real economic price and is not merely virtuous rhetoric. The draft agreement for the fair's new partnership provides for separate advances, deductions only after the cause of damage is established, permission to use designs, and claims concerning delayed payment. Drafting the agreement does not itself bring money into an account. After Parvati's objection, Yusuf's sole bank account is replaced by four separate channels of payment. Following

the first sale, four payment messages arrive. That completed event is kept distinct from speculation about consignments that may follow.

An Inner Story of Father and Son: The Coexistence of Two Sounds

Midway through the chapter Yusuf's son arrives with a toolbox for repairing wires. The tension between learning the inherited loom trade and choosing a new occupation in repairs forms a domestic line different from the commercial partnership. The father at first asks, 'And the loom?' The son replies that he will learn it if he chooses. For a moment, the narrator returns to the father's memory: the loom's first clacking and the son's rounds of offices on the day of the false accusation. In the evening the son hands over an envelope containing his first earnings. Yusuf puts it back into his son's hand. The paired sounds of the loom's clack and the wires' ting construct the next generation's independence at the level of sound.

The chapter's formal limitation is that nearly every occupational counterargument returns to the formulas of 'separate receipt', 'separate responsibility', and 'unfinished decision'. Many characters can articulate their principles with extraordinary clarity in a single day; the reality of being unheard, confusion, and violent bargaining in a crowd receives less attention. Nevertheless, the wet dye sample, the reduced advance, Yusuf's deferred earnings, and his son's different voice keep the formula from becoming entirely flat. The chapter is more successful as a finely differentiated map of the obligations inherent in partnership than as a simple celebration of partnership.

Chapter 167 — Measurement Without an Emperor

A Clash of Two Maps: Fixed Green and the Many Colours of the Seasons

In the last week of Bhadau, two maps are stretched opposite each other on the veranda of the panchayat building. On the district's first map the low-lying wetland, makhana pond, and sand landing form one green strip. In Tara's second survey, the colours of the water change with the seasons, while a white line marks a path for livestock. Lalit Vishwakarma immediately draws a measuring cord over a warped wooden board and shows its physical error. In front of the employee who insists that 'the government map is straight', Devki puts down her bundle of wool on ground labelled 'vacant public land'. The scene creates a direct confrontation: archival classification and daily use are two different statements about the same earth.

The 'emperor' of the title does not introduce another historical character. It becomes a metaphor for the claim that one authority can make the final

measurement. Rama states plainly that the village assembly is not the ultimate court for distributing ownership. Its business today is to record seasonal uses, disagreements, and the date of a new survey. The title acquires depth when the name of a dissenter is entered beside a line upon which others agree. The map begins to serve not as a victor's certificate of exclusive truth but as a way for several incomplete accounts of knowledge to coexist.

Water, Seed, and Labour: The Different Narrative Times of Three Places

At the makhana pond, Phulmati Tiyar's seed, Nandini Bhandari's two vessels of water, and Hira Sahni's measuring rod create an experimental scene. One vessel contains water from the middle, the other from the outside; silt can change the rod's measurement at the very same point. Tara marks the current waterline separately from its potential expansion during the rains. The pond contractor wants the hours of collecting, drying, and cracking to be absorbed into the price of seed. The women workers demand separate recognition of their labour. In Satto Devi's case, genuine seed debt is distinguished from unilateral deductions from wages for cracking makhana. Although the final calculation remains unsettled, deductions from the next consignment are stopped.

The western lowland follows a seasonal pattern: fishing and grazing during the rains, cultivation when the water recedes. Time slots are assigned so that Sushila's rice, Devki's goats, and a young fisher girl's net do not completely displace one another. Devki reduces the platform outside her wool shop by two handspans. This is not simply an occasion for glorifying sacrifice; it is a calculable commercial loss. Drainage is redirected for Phulo Chaurasiya's betel-leaf garden, and partial compensation is provided for two older beds. But the whole cause of the black disease marks is not attributed to drainage. Nandini accepts the water measurements but does not sign a decision to sell land.

The sand landing is the third location. The new sand shown on a map does not return Suraj Gangota's old field, washed away by the river. Aditi requires the seasons and dates of the old and new surveys to be entered separately. Lalit's falsely inflated bill is rejected, but a written assurance that an order for his lawful wages will be issued within seven days is not a payment. Amrita Chauhan's memorial tablet for Nonthara does not dispose of her land claim. Gomti Beldar's current transport wages constitute another, separate claim. One tract of earth, many times, and differing rights: the arrangement of the three locations demonstrates this proposition through events.

Old Water Names: The Difference Between Memory and the Present Location of Events

Sugni Saday's family flood ledger with 'Kosi-Kosika' and the separate old registers of Kiran and Sushila mentioning 'Burhi Gandak' are held insufficient for drawing a modern river line. A new surveyor wants to identify locations by matching similar words, but Sushila first wants the current measurement of her own field. Tara retains the original spellings while removing unverified geographical links. This is an important pause in the novel's craft. Repeated names in memory indicate the narrative's internal past, but cannot fully replace identification of the setting of present events. The different temporal maps within the story address one another without merging.

From Scene to Decision: Uneven Narrative Speeds

The morning panchayat, measurements at the pond, a livestock route through the lowland, and the afternoon at the sand landing turn a single day's meeting into an extensive survey. The successive editing of coloured lines across the board repeatedly directs the reader's attention to small material differences. At the final joint meeting, three seasonal maps are prepared, indicating the rains, the period when water recedes, risks, and temporary restrictions. This creates a place made of multiple lines but cannot yet remove all temporal difficulties. Rama has its final rule written down: where a decision is incomplete, say that it is incomplete. Phulo's compensation and Suraj's claim over land lost to erosion are not equivalent 'successes'.

The final two passages change the chapter's artistic direction. The approved maps become a large digital image and travel to the main office. Devki has no mobile phone; Amrita needs a personal copy; Suraj struggles to read small letters. When told the information is 'online', Devki laughs, 'My goats won't walk their road online.' This audible local voice carries political satire. Rama proposes paper copies, a text that can be read aloud, and a right to request corrections, but distribution has not yet occurred. The story ends precisely on the unperformed action that will cause the opening of Chapter 168.

The Metaphor's Achievement and the Difficulty of Expansion

The confrontation between two maps, a dragging cord, sand slipping through fingers, and 'beneficiary' written on an otherwise blank form are concrete scenes. They anchor the title's grand metaphor of an 'emperor' in lived experience. To read it as an easy announcement of victory over all-powerful administration would erase Nandini's dissent, Suraj's loss, Lalit's unpaid money, and the continuing crisis of a digital copy locked in an

office. The formal risk is that a character who explains the right procedure reappears at every location, increasing instructional dialogue at the expense of spontaneous feeling. The achievement is that the narrator never equates sound procedure with instant happiness. Drawing a line and placing its usable record in people's hands are two separate narrative events.

Chapter 168 — The Copy That Returned

From Bhadau to Aghan: The Document's Journey and the Interval in Time

The narrative moves from the last week of Bhadau in the previous chapter to a morning in Aghan. This explicit interval matters. The digital map that reached only the main office in Chapter 167 now returns to the village as usable paper copies folded inside a wooden box. Instead of a detailed day-by-day account of the intervening administrative preparation, printing, and transport, we see the resulting box. A slip tied with thread at its bottom, lines in blue ink, and the question of how many pages each person should receive all enter the plot. Suraj Gangota's first dramatic question is, 'What will bringing back paper give us?' Tara's answer acknowledges that the earth cannot be restored by a sheet while distinguishing this inability from the duty not to let the loss disappear.

Rama does not abandon the decision to retain the original in the office. Ruhani establishes the copy number, date, history of revisions, and limits on circulation of private names. The 'copy' thus becomes more than a reproduction: it is a usable, revisable instrument reaching the reader with legitimate authority. The steam from Chandrika's hot water and Gomti's action in shielding a map from rain produce a subtle reversal. Where government documents had seemed instruments of command, safeguarding the paper has become labour undertaken by workers themselves.

Donations, Crops, and Settlement: How Decisions Change Once a Copy Is Received

Sudha Rai is ready to announce a land donation for a school, but the tenants' daily route is invisible on the first map. The tenant woman's child, an elderly person's difficulty hearing, and a granddaughter repeating the statement move the scene away from a celebration of names on a plaque and towards the lived reality of a path. The donation is not withdrawn, but its conditions change: first inspect a safe alternative route, obtain the tenants' separate consent, and only then mark the boundary. The teacher placing the prepared letter of thanks back into a bag precisely depicts a postponed ceremony.

Ramesh Kushwaha's three bottle gourds are placed beside the blue drainage mark on the map. The object shows the reader the inequality between colour on paper and the fragile body of a crop. Ramesh's wife separately reads out the damage to cultivation and the labour needed for replanting. A limited drainage trial and a compensation procedure are entered in writing, but no money has yet been deposited. Phulo Chaurasiya's old family paper bearing the word 'Khiroi' is not accepted as automatic proof of today's drain alignment. Accordingly, the benefit of Ramesh's drain does not invalidate a possible loss to Phulo's betel-leaf garden; another site inspection is needed.

At Badri Nonfar's temporary settlement, a weak water supply, deep pits, and the absence of light at night contradict the official line 'resettlement available'. His wife calculates the real distance by means of her empty water pitcher; two morning trips and one evening journey enter the record. Accepting temporary accommodation is distinguished from consenting to give up a permanent home. But the cost of this challenge is that an immediate grant instalment may stop and repair supplies may be delayed. The narrator does not turn the woman into a hero who simply wins. The weary consequences of a dissenting decision are visible too.

Two Debts and a Little Shop: Space for Individual Stories

Ratan Bhuiyan's case involves three separate elements: an old error in counting days, a genuine debt for tools, and an alleged debt attached to a signature he denies. Ratan acknowledges his earlier mistake, which does not make the other false allegation true. The disputed part of the debt is withdrawn from immediate collection, while the small valid borrowing remains; withheld wages have still not reached his bank. Sanket devises signs explaining the meaning of each line for a reader with limited literacy, and also insists that no photograph be taken without Ratan's express consent. The acts of reading, understanding, and gaining control over one's own copy become a narrative outcome in this scene.

Bina Kalar opens her small shop between the acknowledgment of half her ancestral share and the continuing dispute over a room in the house. She begins an independent commercial account although there has been no complete property settlement. Limited room for five items, two bottles removed, and a wooden sign bearing her own name change the scale of narration. From the enormous scene of distributing communal boxes, the reader comes to the actual, restricted autonomy of a little shop. To call this the attainment of 'all rights' would claim more than the novel's present state allows.

Legibility, Audibility, and Control Over Donations: Making a Reader

One group wants an open poster showing everyone's name, caste, and address. Ruhani draws a clear boundary between reasons that should be public and private information about refuge from violence. A public map of use is prepared separately from a detailed personal copy for the individual concerned. An elderly woman gives oral permission to her granddaughter. The words are repeated back, confirmation obtained, and only then is the copy handed over. The granddaughter does not seize the paper but keeps it in accordance with her grandmother's instructions. In such scenes a reader is not merely an educated person who can decipher print. Someone who listens, gives oral consent, or has impaired eyesight is also a reader.

Raghu's question about expense exposes the printing, translation, travel, and labour costs concealed behind a 'free copy' for the community. A donor wants to keep the key to the place where the copies can be accessed. Sarita calls such a donation the prospect of another locked warehouse. At the reading of open accounts, Chandrika, Gomti, Tara, and Geeta read their public portions, not every detail of their private business accounts. Adolescent girls ask for an office to receive corrections and a spoken-information alternative. Paper, audio, and large-print versions are accepted because the rural experience of a mobile phone with no charge is decisive. The chapter is, in fact, a narrative about constructing the reader of an archive in more than one form.

Sarita's Silence and the Elderly Woman's Door: A New Entrance Within Closure

At the final distribution, the donor's plaque remains blank, Ramesh's compensation has not arrived, Badri's disagreement persists, Ratan's valid wages remain withheld, and Bina's little shop is open. The narrator does not crowd these unequal outcomes into a false conclusion. Looking at a blank corner of the map, Sarita remembers Naira's old, empty home. She does not proclaim her dead daughter 'present' inside the copy. When Kabir asks, 'What of those who did not return?', Sarita distinguishes the grief of what cannot be brought back from dues that still can be recovered. This moment of compassion concentrates the chapter's moral energy in lived feeling.

In the antepenultimate passage an elderly tenant with trembling hands asks for water and raises the question of the key to a locked door inside the house. Rama first fills a glass, then enters the problems of the woman's care, consent, and use of her copy on the agenda for the next meeting. The conclusion shows both the unfinished announcement of the donation and the weight of a water pitcher on Badri's wife's body. This scenic cut closes

the parva while shifting its centre from achievements on paper towards an old body, domestic dependence, and the next question of care.

The formal danger remains: the recurring preparation of separate registers for every claim makes some of the characters' independent voices sound formulaic. Yet the elderly woman's request for water before anything else, Sarita's silence at Naira's name, and the immediate adverse consequences for Badri's household break the monotony of procedure. The special achievement is to transform the successful statement 'the record reached the house' into the undecided question 'who will open the house's door?'

Ashvamedha Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 165–168

The Causal Relation Across Four Chapters: From a Sentence to a Usable Copy

The incomplete statement about 'account closure' in Chapter 164 is corrected through restoration of its whole wording in 165; payment for labour remains incomplete. The closing question about threads in 165 becomes the account of a new partnership between Parvati and Yusuf in 166. The temporary livestock path, drainage, and location of collective sales in 166 expand into the map dispute of 167. The digital map reaches the office in 167, but no copy returns to the people. This is the prerequisite for the wooden-box opening of 168. The chapters are joined by more than similarity of theme. The sequence—a severed sentence, separate accounts of labour, shared measurement of a changing place, and actual distribution of copies—successively reconstructs the reader's expectations.

The Organisation of Time: Consecutive Days, Seasonal Gaps, and Entries Through Memory

Chapter 165 is composed as one working day from morning to evening; 166 as a Bhadau market day from dawn to dusk; 167 as a day of surveying in the last week of Bhadau. Chapter 168 leaps to Aghan. The intervening period in which the Bhadau map becomes a 'first usable copy' is not shown directly but conveyed through its subsequent result. Yusuf's memory of an old accusation, ancestral objects belonging to an oil press, Sugni's flood ledger, and Sarita's recollection of Naira generate differing durations and relations of retrospection. It is insufficient to call them all 'flashbacks' in the same sense: some are clearly characters' memories, some are records preserved in objects, and some are brief accounts of the past supplied by the narrator.

Focalisation, Dialogism, and the Variety of Objects

Padma reads the full letter; Parvati reveals invisible hours of work; Devki sees a livestock path in 'vacant land'; Rama questions the actual usability of a distributed copy. These shifts of centre prevent any one person from becoming the all-knowing provider of solutions. Nevertheless, the narrator moulds many characters' speech into the same clear pattern of a verified right, a pending claim, and a separate copy. This is one artistic limit of the novel's polyphony. In resistance to it stand the palpable material forms of Nasim's needle, Sakina's wet dye, Tara and Lalit's cord, Ramesh's gourds, the water pitcher needed by Badri's wife, and the wooden box Rama opens.

A Ledger of Completed Events and Deferred Decisions

In 165 the public meaning of Urmila's labour dues is corrected, but the outstanding amount is not paid; Geeta's partial bank deposit is real. In 166, four separate payment messages arrive following the first sale of cloth, while the origin of the erroneous hospital label and Geeta's remaining company dues are unsettled. In 167, three seasonal maps are approved, partial compensation and two receipts for separate wage categories are recorded, but Suraj's lost field, Amrita's land, and Lalit's lawful pay have not been restored. In 168 usable copies are distributed, Badri's problem is recorded, the disputed component of Ratan's false debt is removed, and Bina's shop opens. Yet compensation, real arrears, a path affected by the donation, and the problem of permanent housing remain alive. Such incompleteness cannot merely be labelled a failure of plot: it creates the necessity of subsequent events.

The Movement of the Whole Ashvamedha: From the Horse's Route to the Return of Labour and Copies

The parva's first group of four chapters (157–160) begins with the horse of the ancient Ashvamedha, Arjuna's and Babhruvahana's relationship in Manipur, the modern travelling camp, and the rewriting of the account of Sarita's intellectual labour. The second group (161–164) centres on credit for co-authorship, the new preface of an old book, and dues still outstanding after Urmila's death. The last four chapters (165–168) address the correct meaning of words, differentiated labour in the marketplace, maps that change with the seasons, and the return of copies carrying usable rights. The movement is a dispersal of the single centre of a triumphant expedition among many ordinary homes. Yet the ancient royal horse sacrifice and the modern panchayat scenes do not literally occur in the same historical moment. Their relation is an intertextual restructuring, not identity of events.

Concluding Critical Judgment on the Parva: The Distance Between Meaning and Access

The strongest formal principle of these twelve chapters is their movement from 'evidence of a right' towards 'the ability to use that right'. Once a name is correctly printed, copies must reach readers; once land is accurately measured, people need maps; once the restricted meaning of a relief-account closure is restored, earned wages remain due; once a joint enterprise is agreed, separate wages must actually reach bank accounts. In every case the final journey of an object or money becomes decisive. Thus the elderly woman's question about the 'door of the house' in Chapter 168 becomes a narrative bridge to the following Ashramavasika Parva, concerned with old age and care. The ultimate conclusion is not that institutions have been repaired. Rather, the story of writing a document cannot be completed without the further story of its recipient, that person's body, and the discomforts of actual use.

Ashvamedha Parva / Uttara Kanda: Complete Narratological Assessment of Chapters 157–168

The overall discussion of the parva's three four-chapter units—the structure of its plots, transformations of time, ancient and modern intertexts, relationships among characters, circulation of documents, and continuity with Uttara Kanda—has been presented jointly under the preceding subsections 'The Movement of the Whole Ashvamedha' and 'Concluding Critical Judgment on the Parva'. The complete assessment should be read as a combined interpretation of partial attainments, unsettled dues, and the emerging question of care for elderly people.

Chapter 169 — Dhritarashtra's Hand

The Overturned Water Pot: From the Movement of Command to the Movement of the Body

The first scene of Ashramavasika Parva begins with a water pot overturning in the old royal residence at Hastinapura. Water spreads across the floor; Dhritarashtra's hand rises in the old gesture of issuing orders, but his body no longer moves in accordance with that gesture. Within a single brief scene, the narrator sets the movement of a hand that persists “even after leaving the throne” against diminished physical capacity. Rather than recounting the broad historical prelude, the alteration of power is shown through a momentary bodily incongruity. The pot, the water, the stool, and the elbow—four concrete things—give the opening

its meaning. The primary sense of the title "Dhritarashtra's Hand" is not a hand that commands, but a hand that chooses when to accept assistance.

When Madhav comes forward to hold his elbow, Dhritarashtra draws his hand away. Having said, "Ask me before touching my body," he does not refuse assistance altogether: he directs Madhav to pick up the pot and tell him where the stool stands, while reserving consent to physical contact as a separate matter. This is a double narrative turn. The former king is accustomed to unilateral commands, yet here the limits of assistance are established through an exchange of questions and answers. In the next scene, the failure to inform him that the stool has been moved extends this small moment: being told that the objects in his room have changed position is also part of an older person's right to conduct his life.

Dhritarashtra, Vidura, and the Working Woman: Different Rights Within One Scene

Confronted with Yudhishthira's proposed special meal, Dhritarashtra questions the measures of grain. The account of two widowed cooks receiving their shares late turns the narrative from the aged king's personal weakness toward the distribution of labour's returns. Gandhari's brief intervention—that the grain received by a woman working in the kitchen is not charity for an old body but her share for her work—changes the characters' centres of focalisation. Dhritarashtra hears about Madhav's wages, but no scene establishes that the accounts are immediately corrected. The actual outcome goes no further than a written leaf prepared by Sanjaya and an opportunity for Madhav to state his account.

Vidura's arrival opens a brief analepsis into ancient political memory. Dhritarashtra acknowledges his responsibility for earlier decisions made from attachment to his sons. Vidura refuses to pronounce him innocent on the spot, yet neither does he declare every pleasure of life forbidden because the king is old. Dhritarashtra's holding of his palm, followed by Vidura's gentle withdrawal of his hand, provides a visual ending to their exchange. The gesture carries both the memory of wrongdoing and a boundary upon closeness. Thereafter an elderly cook arrives to report a shortfall in the measure. She is not a stage-managed figure who comes to beg forgiveness, but a person bearing an independent claim. Her appearance interrupts the royal narrative of remorse with the everyday time of a working woman.

Its critical significance is that the narrator does not treat Dhritarashtra's self-admission as the final solution. Madhav is concerned with bringing grain home for his child; he has not come to hear moral pronouncements from an elderly king and take part in a ceremony of self-purification. The woman leaves with her bundle, without touching the king's feet. Such small refusals provide a basis for narrative polyphony: an inward change

may have begun in the king, but the lives around him are not obliged to become certificates of that transformation.

The Cut from the Ancient to the Modern: Door, Granddaughter, and Invitation

In the twelfth passage, Dhritarashtra asks permission before taking Gandhari's hand; she responds by preserving her right to choose her future path. Immediately afterwards, the thirteenth passage marks an explicit shift in story time with the words "Videhapur, 2040." This change is neither a character's rebirth nor two pieces of evidence concerning the same event. It creates an arrangement in which the reader examines one question under different conditions in different eras. The ancient stool is replaced by the swollen door of a modern house, the royal attendant by a granddaughter, and the state's grain by a panchayat repair register.

The elderly woman tenant permits her granddaughter to read a copy, but not to take decisions in her name. The distinction between a departmental inspection and an invited guest, the condition of two local witnesses, and the resolve not to open a private chest all turn their exchanges into a contest over control of physical space. The damp lower panel of the door is repaired, but neither replacement of the entire frame nor departure from the house has been decided. An old nail and a small fragment of timber remain in the memories of the granddaughter and the elderly woman; they do not turn into a written title deed. The material particularity of an object here gives narrative form to abstract assertions of rights.

The Gloss of Printing and Actual Labour: Constructing a Dramatic Temptation

The printing company's attractive sample booklet introduces a new conflict midway through the chapter. Its offer of large print, an audio version, and secure digital storage has genuine usefulness; Ratan Bhuiyan really does find large print helpful. But the single-server arrangement, five-year price provisions, and absence of an alternative means of obtaining an export copy written underneath alter the meaning of the initial offer. The reader first encounters a useful object, and only then its hidden dependency. Ruhani and Sanket read the representative's claim of "security" differently. The refusal to sign immediately is an accomplished event; the company's permanent exclusion is not.

The proposal to classify adolescent girls' reading work as "voluntary service" exposes class inequality within educational work itself. Ruhani links the time treated as unpaid to the loss of the students' opportunities to study. Sanket publicly acknowledges the incompleteness of his budget. The narrative repeats its reliable means of identifying injustice—names,

payment, consent, access—but something important also occurs: the cheap plan now appears expensive, while the actual social source of its cost becomes visible. A decision is made in favour of a local copy, restricted private access, and annual review; a separate provision for supporting poorer families is proposed.

Narrative Dimensions, the Final Door, and Critical Limits

The chapter's temporal span divides into two sequences of scenes, from ancient dawn to night and from modern morning to evening. The narrator gains access to Dhritarashtra's momentary anger, Yudhishthira's hesitation, Sanket's error, and the elderly woman's caution; focalisation does not remain permanently with one person. Dialogue is extremely dense, whereas the movement of water, the sound of cutting wood, wet clothing, and trembling fingers slow the movement of words. This contrast in form takes the reader from principles of decision-making to the everyday application of those principles.

In the final scene the new door opens easily, but before handing her key to her granddaughter the elderly woman asks whether she wishes to stay the night. Permission before the pot and a question before the key close the chapter's circle, while the question of Gandhari's impending journey remains open. The artistic limitation is that almost every conflict turns into unusually well-ordered ethical dialogue; the density of minor administrative decisions sometimes allows too little room for the characters' uncomfortable silences. Nevertheless, the elderly woman's physical home, Madhav's unpaid wages, and the still unresolved threat of corporate control prevent the ending from becoming an easy declaration of victory.

Chapter 170 — Gandhari's Departure

The Knot in the Bundle: Not a Farewell but the Beginning of a Decision

After the Dhritarashtra–Gandhari exchange in the preceding chapter, the story begins again at dawn in ancient Hastinapura. Gandhari opens and reties a bundle containing dried medicine, two ordinary garments, and old thread. Against the royal palace's abundant stores, the few things she chooses for herself to take on the journey constitute the narrative's first visual counterpoint. The old thread is not immediately announced as a clue to some mystery; it remains a tangible object limiting the weight of her life. When Dhritarashtra speaks of dust upon the forest road, Gandhari answers by mentioning the dust that has accumulated in the royal

residence. The reply reveals, in a sentence, the long preparation behind her decision to leave.

Gandhari's central declaration—"I am not your eyes; I am your wife"—challenges the old account of an identity merged within marriage. She distinguishes leaving Dhritarashtra from leaving the daily routine of the royal palace; if he wishes, her husband can accompany her for reasons of his own. Touching the old edge of her blindfold, she reminds him that a single decision to cover her eyes cannot take away the right to every subsequent choice in her life. The narrator uses the epic sign not as a fixed symbol but as a centre of the character's renewed self-definition.

The Proposal of Safety and the Real Infrastructure of Travel

Yudhishthira's plea to remain in the gardens, with quiet accommodation and medicines arranged, initially sounds like reasonable concern. But Gandhari asks who ever consulted her about the choice of residence. The king's fear is not villainised: he himself admits that his concern for safety seeks to restrain her will. The narrative then descends into more important material details: which hermitage has water and grain, whether its consent has been obtained, why the eastern landing is slippery after rain, and how the western road, though longer, offers shelter for the night. Through this actual consideration of place, freedom becomes an inquiry into the practical possibility of travel, not a slogan.

Vidura's brief scene closes the shortcut by which Gandhari's decision might be taken to absolve her entirely of wrongdoing. Going to the forest does not erase sins; how one treats other people each day remains a question for the future. Picking up the broken wheel of a wooden toy and remembering the earlier neglect of an injured stable boy constitute a dramatic analepsis. Even at the centre of maternal grief, Gandhari recognises the suffering of another child within her own royal household. She leaves the toy in the palace; she does not confine the right to memory inside her bundle.

The Separate Voice of Dependent Labour and Consent to Both Journeys

The elderly kitchen attendant's claim for three days' wages carries forward from the previous chapter, but the sum has still not been received. Gandhari stipulates that no one's dues may be deducted to finance her farewell meal; answering the woman's question, "Blessings?", she recognises the need for payment. Madhav's case is still more concrete. Gandhari frames her request for service as a "question" rather than an "order." Because of his elderly mother, child, and outstanding wages, Madhav agrees to serve only as far as the first stop, not for life. Amid the

ceremonial dignity of a royal journey, this limited consent opens the worker's own timeline.

Dhritarashtra eventually decides to accompany her, but acknowledges the weakness of his legs. Gandhari insists that they have made decisions for different reasons; a carriage may be retained for practical assistance, not for a triumphal display. The removal of a ceremonial arch from the city gate turns a royal farewell into a question of public passage. Protecting the normal route of people carrying water becomes more important than cries of victory. Another widow, whose son died in the war, states her name; hearing it does not make her grief identical with Gandhari's. The undissolved voice of ordinary people amid the royal family's vast suffering is an important distinction in the novel.

The Bus of 2040: Not Imitation but Intertextual Transformation

The sixteenth passage cuts away from the ancient journey, stating "Videhapur, 2040," and returns to the elderly modern tenant's home. The door's new lower panel has been repaired; now she wishes to spend three days visiting her natal village, the embankment of an old pond, and the memory of her mother carrying earth. At the level of the represented reality, the transition is specific. One woman leaves because of grief in a royal palace; another wishes to retain the key to her own home while visiting the site of her family's labouring past. To treat the two journeys as one event would erase the distance established by the novel itself.

The granddaughter's sewing work and the question of care for the older woman open up tensions between the separate times of two independent characters. The panchayat works out a plan concerning alternatives, route, medicines, stopping places, an emergency contact, and the host's consent; it does not prohibit the journey. On the telephone, the young woman who would host her mentions the needs of her elderly mother and child, so that the older guest's right does not turn into a command that another family provide free care. The familiar woman driver's wages are stated explicitly. These practical limits to assistance counterbalance a romantic portrayal of the protagonist's freedom.

The proposal for a digital travel pass revives the attempt to capture private data that was rejected the previous day. The elderly woman asks why a bus ticket requires her entire medical history; a limited emergency contact and a paper list of medicines are prepared separately. This time Sudha's donation is shown as received by the bank, but the donation is accepted only for repairing the door; expenditure on the journey remains a separate choice. Lalit's government repair bill is still unpaid. The payment of wages for the older woman's new door does not discharge his other outstanding

dues. The distinction preserves the independent outcomes of dispersed plot lines.

The Right to Stop Along the Way: Duration, Closure, and Limits

At the bus stop the granddaughter asks permission before giving the older woman a hand onto the step. Parallel to Gandhari's ancient bundle, the older woman's shawl, coin, medicine pouch, and key make the modern scene tangible. A neighbouring shopkeeper asks for her full address, but she gives only the name of the next stop. The combined sounds—vegetable baskets, market travellers, and bus dust—echo the ceremonial arch of the royal departure. By the end, the journey's duration is not an established accomplishment: she has only advanced as far as the first stop. The narrator does not turn this tired traveller into an invincible heroine.

The final passage explicitly states that Gandhari in the royal house and the bus journey of 2040 are not two proofs of the same event. Such narratorial clarification prevents an excessive intertextual reading, but also raises a formal question: when the scenes have already established the distinction, does the narrator's declaration of it again at the end reduce the reader's room for active interpretation? Many characters, moreover, repeatedly articulate the right to choose in unusually explicit language. Yet the possibility of stopping at the first stage, the granddaughter's sewing, and the workers' unpaid dues keep the chapter from becoming merely a slogan. The journey left open creates space for a revised plan in the following chapter.

Chapter 171 — Kunti's Remaining Words

A Grain of Rice on a Plate and the Space for What Remains Unsaid

Immediately after Gandhari's departure, Kunti notices a brass plate with a single dry grain of rice upon it in the ancient royal palace. A maid reaches for it, but Kunti decides to clean the plate herself. A household task deemed inconsistent with the dignity of a queen mother gives her a small period of independence in which no permission need be sought. The overturned pot in Chapter 169, the bundle in Chapter 170, and the plate in Chapter 171 form three distinct openings through objects, by means of which the immense histories of the epic's aged characters are distributed into the body's daily actions. Gandhari's absence and the palace corridor, now seeming larger, increase tension through an empty space.

Yudhishthira calls his mother his emotional support within the palace. Kunti repeats her decision, but her son initially takes it for a passing symptom of fatigue. Her reply—"Do not turn my resolve into an illness of exhaustion"—sharpens a conflict over narrative authority. Who may

interpret another character's experience, and whose decision must the other accept? The narrator shows Yudhishthira's fear of loss, so he is not cast as a villain; but the legitimacy of his fear gives him no right to detain his mother.

Karna's Absent Presence: Analepsis and the Time of Remorse

Arjuna asks, "Is there anything you still have to say?" without immediately naming Karna. By saying that this unspoken name is present, the narrator opens the meaning of the scene. Kunti then accepts responsibility for concealing her maternity of Karna, but refuses to reduce the dead Karna's friendships, life, and choices to a subsidiary branch of the royal genealogy. This segment of memory is not merely a fresh revelation in the chronology of events: Karna's life, the time of war, the later admission, and the present question of family records bring four temporal movements into one conversation. The narrated time is brief; the ethical time cannot be crossed so quickly.

Yudhishthira already knows the truth of Karna's birth. The issue here is not his "first knowledge," but how to record a dead person's life in a social register. Kunti does not automatically receive forgiveness from her sons; Arjuna has the freedom to submit questions in writing or to keep his distance. The dust of the battlefield arising in Arjuna's memory is an internal analepsis, but it is not allowed to expand into another extended battle scene on the page. The dialogue of the present gathering thereby gives new significance to the wounded centre of the past without changing its outcome.

The dialogue of Nakula and Sahadeva brings in the absent memory of Madri. Kunti's insistence that upbringing is not the final instalment of a debt changes the metaphor of maternity as something "owed." Within the narrative of sacrifice around the journey from the fire to the forest, Draupadi raises the labour of unnamed cooks and women carrying water. The chapter continually looks beyond the emotional centre of the ancient royal family toward the time of other dependent people; alongside the grand rasa of renunciation, the accounts of organising a journey also matter.

The First Forest Stop: A Shared Journey, Separate Decisions

Kunti does not ask her five sons' permission; she does not allow love, fear, objection, or support to become formal powers of authorisation. Her question to a young woman collecting water near the bridge about the labour of repairing it opens a small social space outside the central family. Reaching Gandhari, Kunti does not impose the demand that they travel together. They accept companionship as far as the next stopping place,

followed by another decision made separately. The fifteenth passage gives the ancient sequence a provisional completion, not a final outcome of forest dwelling.

The distinguishing feature of this section is that Kunti's longstanding guilt is not measured solely through the intensity of grief. Gandhari's final response—that bearing one's burden and placing it on somebody else are different—comes in the chapter's last passage. This displaced ending lets the ancient journey break off amid the modern one before returning; the order of presentation asks readers to remember the two narrative lines separately.

The Modern Stop: Revision of a Plan and the Separate Personhood of Family Members

In the sixteenth passage, the elderly woman of Videhapur in 2040 gets off at the first bus stop and suspends her journey because of fatigue. The possible halt of Chapter 170 here becomes an actual decision; it does not change her rights over her home. The dharmashala register's entry "responsible male member of the family" is called into question by the older woman's self-identification. The driver distinguishes an emergency contact from a substitute who could consent as owner. In this way a small register incident at a temporary lodging tests Gandhari's philosophical discussion of departure under new social conditions.

The granddaughter stops the sewing machine's pedal to answer the telephone and starts it again after the conversation. The device's return makes her own working time visible. The older woman says that people's comments do not own the time of either generation. But at the next annual review the company proposes "integrated family authority," under which one family member's digital signature would replace each adult's separate consent. Compassion within a home and the contract for a commercial service thus make different narrative uses of the word "family."

Kabir personally fills in an application to add the name that records his verified history of upbringing; he does not enter conjecture in the unresolved birth field. Naira's absence forms the background of Sarita's grief, while Kabir's documented upbringing and present adult choice give the scene a separate narrative axis. Recollection of the preceding chapters is not merely background: Kabir's actual signature is a new event, though the office has not yet approved the addition of the name. Payment of Lalit's correctly signed government repair bill has still not reached his bank account. The narrator distinguishes the appearance of approval from the absence of receipt. These two lines continue with incomplete outcomes concerning both inheritance and dues.

Divided Narrative Time, Narratorial Caution, and Critical Judgment

The textual order of Chapter 171 is not linear: first the ancient dawn to the initial stopping place (passages 1–15), then the modern stop and public review (16–30), and finally a return to the ancient night near the fire (31). This "return" completes the emotional closure of Kunti's remaining words, while the modern narrative's disputes remain open. Maithili reads the pages about the forest journey without treating them as contemporary judicial evidence. The presence of this internal character-reader allows the novel itself to state the limits of its intertextual reading.

A critical limitation is that Kunti, Gandhari, Sarita, Rama, and the elderly woman often articulate the differences among autonomy, love, and evidence with extraordinary clarity. The inner instability of Karna's complicated relationship, the sons' doubts, and the women's silences might have been given longer scenes. Yet the single grain on the plate, the fold of a scarf, the sewing machine's pedal, and the empty corridor of the palace connect didactic exchanges to tangible life. In the end, Kunti chooses not to obtain forgiveness but to refrain from placing her burden upon another. This is not an immediate triumph of atonement but the start of an uncertain shared journey.

Chapter 172 — Ishaan's Room

A Door Difficult to Open: From Private Scholarship to Public Reading

Moving away from the journeys of older people across the preceding three chapters, Chapter 172 opens directly in Videhapur in 2040. Ishaan's hand catches as he turns the lock to a back room in the library; the door swollen by damp, papers on the table, and a loosened nameplate appear within one scene. At first this room seems to be the place of a solitary scholar's reputation, but the committee's notice that it must become a public children's reading room within seven days reverses the narrative situation. The room was allocated for research use, not as a permanent private lease. Only belatedly does Ishaan see that children have been reading outside its closed door.

The loose nameplate might have become a simple emblem of his eroding individual entitlement, but the story turns it into a practical narrative object. One screw comes out; the other is rusted. Eventually the metal remains with the library for reuse. Through the recurrence of the object from the opening into the middle, the answer to "Who owns this room?" changes direction: responsibility for vacating it, protection of private pages, a place where children can read, and registration of books belonging to the public.

A Brief Analepsis of the Old Credit Dispute and the Limits of a Relationship

The third opening passage briefly recalls the earlier omission of Maithili's original argument and Sarita's copying labour. The corrected attribution has been made public in the new preface, but Ishaan's invitations and friendships have diminished since then. The narrator does not assign two experiences to the same category: legitimate social consequences of challenging his actions and the cruelty of enjoying another person's humiliation. That distinction does not render the character's defence wholly valid, but neither does it turn his humiliation into the novel's entertainment.

Maithili comes to the room and takes her original handwritten pages. Ishaan seeks permission to keep a usable copy of the jointly written section; Maithili sets a boundary against handing over pages from her private notebook. She does not treat the previous correction of coauthorship as the restoration of marital life together. The incident brings possession of documents and an intimate relationship to the same table, while making clear that each requires its own decision. Ishaan wishes to open a conversation about memories, but Maithili stands holding her papers; this bodily position creates a harder image of distance than the narrator's explanation does.

In the final section, Maithili writes conditions for a public lecture: questions and sources must be sent beforehand. She makes no decision on their private relationship in this letter. Ishaan's private line, "Acknowledging a wrong is not a means of earning a reward," is only a claim of transformation. The reader's evidence lies in subsequent conduct: not telephoning her, continuing his studies while awaiting an answer to the letter, and not turning Maithili's reply into a certificate for public display. There is no complete marital reconciliation in this chapter.

Many Voices in the Dispute Over the Room: Committee, Readers, and Employees

Rukhsana wants a bright room for children but opposes publicly ridiculing Ishaan over the error of attribution. Anand advises going to court; Ishaan distinguishes seizure of private pages from the obligation to vacate a public room. Rohit's list separates private documents from books intended for open shelves. A little girl asks, "Does the big book have pictures?" and then says, "I want to read the questions." The innocent curiosity in this question displaces the scholar's lost title from the centre of the scene.

At a subsequent meeting of the library committee, a private publisher offers to donate tables and shelves on condition of five years of compulsory

book purchases. The proposal is linked as a narrative motif to the printing company's control through "free" facilities in Chapter 169, but there is no proof that it is the same company. At the public hearing Ishaan raises questions beyond his private interests, while Rukhsana demands a purchase register covering multiple publishers. The decision is to suspend acceptance of the assistance until its terms are rewritten, without delaying the opening date. This complication gives the institutional scene a more realistically differentiated pace than an ideal moral pronouncement would.

Receipts, Wages, and the Deferred Outcome of Evidence

A receipt for Sarita's work found in an old chest has page numbers, but no confirmation of actual payment. Ishaan forwards it for an inquiry into outstanding dues. Sarita has the envelope sealed only after recording a photograph of the original, the page numbers, and the identity of its writer. She makes clear that the assessed payment for copying and the unquantified time spent caring for a household do not belong under a single heading of charity. Finding the page is an accomplished event; the money reaching her bank account has not happened. The narrator keeps this difference alive through Sarita's dissatisfaction rather than dissolving it in Ishaan's remorse.

Before the new reading room opens, Rani the cleaner raises questions of dust, equipment, and remuneration. The committee approves gloves, a face covering, and wages for additional time. The removal of the nameplate by a craftsperson and the cleaning worker's explicitly recognised labour form a sequence of scenes; the bodily time required to make the children's reading room available is not overlooked. At the opening, corrected joint authorship appears on the first page of a public book, with Sarita's credit included; a separate notice states that her claim for payment remains under review. Printing the right name and fully receiving the money belong to two different narrative levels.

Listening Instead of Teaching: A Character's Limited Reconstruction

Ishaan struggles with sheets blowing in the wind beneath the roof of his house; once the nameplate is removed, he does not receive the seat of a grand lecturer. Munna arrives for help with a problem, but will not offer deference to his former status as its price. Munna's counter-question about Ishaan's example of smoke and mist, and his objection that a scholar's name cannot prove a proposition true, become an enacted scene. Writing "Answer under revision" is an action marking the character's change of ideas. The criticism here is not an examination of the classical content of the argument, but of the balance of power in a classroom exchange.

After this lesson, Ishaan makes the first exercise in the public reading room free, while stating the fee for private teaching labour in advance. On the opening day Rohit asks him to teach the first lesson; he chooses to listen that day. The narrative movement has reached from a loss of outward reputation toward a new discipline of the inner life. But the narrator does not turn Ishaan's rehabilitation into a coronation: an error remains in Munna's exercise book, other children write their names in the reading room, and Ishaan sits on an ordinary bench outside.

Composition and Artistic Limits: A Revised Text, an Unrevised Relationship

The chapter is entirely situated in modern time, with almost no direct scene from the ancient epic. It therefore makes a clear formal break from the double-period structure of the preceding three chapters. The one-week deadline, “two days later,” “the following dawn,” the opening, and the evening allow the room to become a public reading room within seven days. The copy bearing joint credit, a private envelope, a receipt for unpaid money, the nameplate, and a pupil's notebook create a sequence of recurring objects. The chapter's phrase “the path of evidence being corrected” is a new heading, not a definitive grant of liberation.

The artistic risk is that Munna, the girl, Rukhsana, and Ishaan repeatedly express precisely the ethical question that readers could have inferred from the scene for themselves. Ishaan's transformation is narrated in an excessively orderly manner; there is little room for the renewed emergence of old insecurity, anger, or serious self-interest. Nevertheless, the torn receipt, the envelope of private pages, the cost of Rani's cleaning, and Maithili's conditional letter prevent the character from being absorbed into a single formula of self-redemption. At the end, the new reading room belongs to the town; Maithili's next answer will come from her own position, and the question of Sarita's actual payment remains open.

Ashramavasika Parva / Uttara Kanda — Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 169–172

Entering the Parva: Whose Voice Before Taking Another's Hand?

At the close of Ashvamedha Parva, a correctable copy returns to the people; the first four chapters of Ashramavasika Parva extend that question to an ageing body, the key to a home, consent to travel, and a public reading room. At every point—the pot and consent to touch in 169 and the elderly woman's door; the bundle and bus step in 170; the plate and dharmashala register in 171; and the lock and nameplate in 172—access, assistance, and authority are not one and the same action. The opening of the parva is

therefore not a simple account of the gradual surrender of royal power, but a narrative of separate individual decisions within relationships of affection.

The event sequence of these four chapters has a distinct causal bridge. In 169 Dhritarashtra asks permission to touch and Gandhari announces her intended departure; in 170 Gandhari actually leaves, while the modern older woman forms her own travel decision. In 171 Kunti reaches the forest through a separate emotional crisis, the modern woman decides to stop at the first stage, and Kabir submits an application concerning the name in his upbringing record. In 172 the journeys of older people recede and Ishaan's library space is redistributed. The earlier questions of coauthorship, his own place, and another person's rights acquire a new institutional narrative.

Chapter 169 cleanly divides a sequence from dawn to night in the ancient royal residence and from morning to evening in the modern panchayat. In 170 ancient time continues as far as the first stop on the forest route, followed by the modern bus journey; the last passage explicitly distinguishes the two. Chapter 171 is edited more intricately: first the ancient journey into the forest, then the modern stop and annual review in 2040, and finally a return to Kunti and Gandhari's conversation at night. The seven days of modern narrative in 172 leave direct epic scenes behind and dwell on the fine sequence of local time. These differences keep the four chapters from seeming like a uniform mythic adaptation.

Memory of the past also occurs to differing degrees. In 169 Dhritarashtra briefly recalls his court and his attachment to his sons; in 170 a broken toy reminds Gandhari of a neglected boy's injury; in 171 Karna's concealed maternity is present as an unspoken name at the current gathering; in 172 Ishaan's old misattribution is made known through a revised preface. The past neither happens again nor disappears: every present decision determines a new position in relation to it.

Narrator and Polyphony: The Independent Time of Supporting Characters

The third-person narrator shifts focalisation among the king's anger, Yudhishthira's fear, Arjuna's memory, Ishaan's discomfort, and the modern older woman's fatigue. Yet the particular significance emerges from voices that royal or intellectual narratives might have relegated to the margins: Madhav's three days of wages, the kitchen worker's grain, the granddaughter's sewing, the paid work of a woman driver, Kabir's separate identity through upbringing, and the cost of Rani's cleaning. If these characters remained merely illustrations of philosophical propositions,

polyphony would diminish. In many places their separate economic times keep the scenes in productive disagreement.

Recurring symbols also carry subtle differences. When Dhritarashtra's hand receives water from Madhav, the scene concerns consent to touch; when Gandhari's hand reaches Dhritarashtra, a separate choice within marriage; when the elderly woman's hand rises to the bus step, temporary help; when Ishaan's hand releases the nameplate, acceptance of a public room's rights. The social significance changes across four situations using the same motif. The reader must therefore recognise successive transformations of relationships, rather than impose a single universal meaning on "hand."

Completed, Undecided, and Merely Proposed Outcomes

In 169 the older woman's door receives limited repairs, an annual review procedure is agreed, and immediate signature on the company's controlling contract is prevented; Madhav's unpaid dues remain unsettled. In 170 Gandhari departs and the older woman's first bus stage is completed; Sudha's repair donation reaches the bank, but Lalit's separate government repair arrears do not. In 171 Kunti leaves for the forest, the older woman stops at the first stage, Kabir submits his own application, and the company's collective-consent condition is rejected; Kabir's application has not been approved, and Lalit's bank payment remains outstanding. In 172 Ishaan's room becomes a public reading room, Maithili receives her original pages, and corrected credit is printed; Sarita has not finally been paid, and there is no marital reunion.

These differing outcomes are a structural achievement of the novel. "Approved" on a form does not necessarily mean money has arrived; beginning a journey does not necessarily mean reaching the intended village; correcting an attribution does not necessarily restore a personal relationship. But repeated direct verbal declarations of these differences also mark a critical limit. Characters almost always argue in ethically self-aware terms; uncertain desire, practical error, awkward silence, and the densely lived experience of antagonistic characters can be submerged beneath the propositions.

Interim Judgment and Indications for the Rest of the Parva

The distinctive accomplishment of these four chapters is to make old age not merely a question of passive care but one of narrative time and choice. The elderly woman cannot cover the whole route on the first day; that is not failure but the exercise of freedom to stop. Kunti does not obtain forgiveness by stating her remaining truth; Ishaan does not buy Maithili's

affection by correcting coauthorship credit. The helper's love and the recipient's choice remain separate within the narrative.

Ashramavasika Parva has reached only the first four chapters of its projected 169–180 sequence; it would be inappropriate to treat this assessment as a judgment on the whole parva. The chief unresolved question entering Chapter 173, "Maithili's Distance," is how Ishaan's public correction and Maithili's private decision will meet—or remain apart—within narrative space, and how long the new library arrangement will give accurate credit and payment to formerly invisible labour. What the original text does not establish as completed is not being assigned a definite future outcome on the basis of conjecture.

Chapter 173 — Maithili's Distance

An Opening with Two Keys: Separate Stories of Corrected Credit and the Decision Where to Live

At dawn in 2040, Maithili places two keys separately on her table: one to the study room she rents, the other to Ishaan's old house. This opening scene connects the previous chapter's public correction of attribution to a new circumstance in private life, without predetermining its outcome. The lecture pages written during the night have dried; an answer about the private relationship has still not been written. The contrast between dry paper and an unwritten reply is the narrative's point of departure: a text may be ready for public discussion, while a decision about intimacy cannot necessarily proceed at the same speed. The two keys are not merely objects of opposition; they indicate the actual uses of and entitlements to different doors.

On old pages there are interventions by Ishaan and Maithili in red and black ink. The questions had remained, but the woman's name as an author was omitted from the earlier edition; the revised edition restores it. This brief analepsis supplies necessary background to the chapter's present, without making "restoring the name" synonymous with "restoring the days gone by." From the opening the reader knows that establishing rightful coauthorship is an achievement, not a narrative necessity of marital reconciliation. The author's criticism here inheres in the story's independence of decision, rather than in any final declaration by Maithili.

The Error on the Programme: An Unauthorised Private Extension of a Public Narrative

The programme Rukhsana brings includes the heading "Reunion of the Celebrated Couple" alongside the book's coauthorship. This is the first

clear disruption in the plot. A line at the foot of the programme imposes an imagined conclusion of the study committee upon Maithili's life. She sets conditions for her public appearance: discussion of arguments, separate speaking times for the two speakers, and no promotion of their private marriage. Rukhsana sends a correction notice. Rather than merely tearing up the first sheet and treating the matter as over, a copy of the correction is attached to it. The narrative event thus proceeds through four stages—publication of misinformation, objection, corrective action, and preservation of a record of the original error—and the actual atmosphere of the meeting begins to change.

During the interval, Rajan's two garlands and a proposed photograph render the dispute visible again. Maithili leaves by the side of the platform; Ishaan does not accept a garland; the photographer lowers his camera, but Rajan remains annoyed. No wholesale change in public opinion occurs. Some spectators leave, and the money spent on donations becomes contentious. Rukhsana distinguishes recording expenses in a public account from making a woman perform a personal decision in return for that expense. The programme, garlands, camera, and expense ledger become different instruments for constructing a misleading social narrative.

The Chest at the Threshold and a Scene of Revised Cooperation

The scene in the old house is filled with the possibility of intimate memory. The creak of a jammed window reminds Maithili of a shared evening of study during the rains. The memory is tender, and the character does not deny its truth; but past happiness cannot create a present agreement by itself. Packing belongings—clothes, a brass water pot given by her mother, private letters, and jointly purchased books—makes different categories of ownership visible. Maithili's line between "help me carry the chest" and "do not read the letters inside" brings a rule off the page into bodily cooperation. The two turn the object sideways to pass it through the doorway.

Readers would err by treating this scene as a metaphor for reunion. Carrying the chest is successful joint labour, not a decision to live in the house again. The receipt for Sarita's unpaid copying work cuts into this emotional scene from another social timescale. Maithili makes clear that her own printed coauthorship credit does not discharge the money owed for Sarita's distinct labour. Ishaan agrees that the accounts must remain open until independently examined, while Sarita leaves only after obtaining a written acknowledgment. This third voice prevents the conflict of a private relationship from being reduced to "the settlement of two intellectuals."

Living Intellectual Disagreement in the Reading Room and the Narrator's Distribution of Knowledge

At the public reading Maithili speaks first; both her original handwritten questions and the revised published copy are presented. She does not place the status of coauthor beyond criticism by the student audience. Munna's question about the correct answer after an error, the little girl's possibility of revising the next edition, and Ishaan's willingness to revise rather than deny all make the text something that can be tested again instead of a static moral victory. During Ishaan's lecture, Maithili publicly challenges an incomplete argument. The narrative achievement is not that "both agreed," but that intellectual disagreement survives their personal distance.

The third-person narrator shows Maithili's private anxiety, Ishaan's pain, and the students' reactions. But no one side's feelings become conclusive proof. Rukhsana's admission of error, Rajan's irritation, a questioner's silence, and Leela's practical question about citation all view the same event from different social locations. Advice to Leela to cite both the mistaken first edition and its correction notice offers a small further solution to the narrative's problem of "printed memory." Its conclusion is not that publication history should be erased and replaced with a new, immaculate history.

The Rent Receipt, the Open Lane, and an Undecided Future

It would be easy to call Maithili's separate dwelling a symbol of independence, but the story itself shows the economic conditions of that independence. The rent receipt is corrected to her name alone; she must pay for the room out of teaching and translation earnings, while her income for the following fortnight is uncertain. Free public lessons and paid private proofreading labour are kept separate. A child's drawing of a shared garden with separate doors, followed by the water pipe shared by two tenants, makes distance through recurring objects something other than mutual indifference. This modern spatial arrangement gives the chapter's conceptual question material form beyond paper, in water, rent, paths, and access.

The newspaper publishes a small correction, but no one knows how many people read the original misleading item; a new rule requiring consent for photographs is merely proposed. Maithili sends Ishaan a message about an error in a textual source; the time to discuss their personal relationship remains separate. At the end, Champa arrives with her mother's illegible medical prescription. The narrator does not stop Maithili's chapter with a glittering conclusion about independence, but turns it toward the difficult opening of another story of women's work and care. A limitation is that the characters repeatedly offer highly orderly explanations; some scenes of

felt silence and economic insecurity may be caught inside that explanatory framework. Nevertheless, Champa's arrival at the end establishes the chapter's open structure.

Chapter 174 — Mother's Medicine

Blurred Letters and Two Clocks: The Opening Tension Between Treatment and Livelihood

At the opening of this chapter, one letter on the mother's prescription has spread because of water, only two doses remain in the box, and the morning light of the shelter has not yet reached the veranda. The scene immediately creates a crisis of time, but no character guesses a medicine's name from the illegible writing. The time needed for Champa to sew six bags, her mother's pain, and the uncertainty of approaching rent converge in a single morning. Maithili writes the time needed for treatment and the time needed to earn money on two separate sheets of paper. The tension between these simultaneous schedules is the story's central force: bodily pain cannot wait, but abruptly stopping the labour that provides a livelihood endangers the cost of subsequent treatment.

The mother understands her expenses as a burden upon her daughter; Champa does not consider written accounts an insult to affection. Rukhsana separates food expenses from the cost of personal medicines, and a condition is agreed for recording paid hours for Zubaida's kitchen shift. These brief scenes do not offer one emotional solution to the mother's and daughter's painful relationship; they pose material questions about arranging labour. The transfer of assistance from one woman to the unpaid labour of another does not escape the story's notice. The voices of the group support one another, while financial limits and individual fears remain distinct.

The Hospital Sequence: Who Has Authority to Speak About Medical Treatment?

The crowd at the hospital gate, difficulty finding a seat, and public questions about the illness slow the sequence of scenes. Champa asks for suitable access for her mother, but does not take her mother's speaking place before the clinician. The mother herself describes her pain, tiredness, and the timing of her medicines; after an examination she receives a new prescription. The event in the text is unambiguous: the old illegible prescription is replaced by new instructions checked by the doctor, a date for the next examination, and medicines actually purchased. This is not an external medical textbook; the central concern is the patient's presence as a speaking subject within the exchange about treatment.

Successful consultation at the hospital and payment for medicines do not remove anxiety over the month's income. The narrative divides the bill into three amounts—consultation, medicines, and travel—rather than making the prescription a final document of deliverance. The mother herself asks about altering instructions, and the doctor answers clearly. Champa prepares a written timetable rather than asserting a right to control her mother's arm. The "story" of treatment is not the omniscient pronouncement of an outside expert, but a relationship formed among an embodied patient, practicable instructions, and future costs that remain only partly met.

Amresh Arrives: A Separate Narrative Time for Private Desire

Amresh meets them outside the hospital, but his offer to fetch the medicines does not receive a romantic answer; Champa wishes to take a half-hour walk in the evening. Her mother acknowledges her concern without turning it into a final exercise of social control over her daughter's wish. In the evening Amresh arrives at the appointed time, while Champa is late because she is finishing the last seam of her sewing. A small new scene of waiting emerges: the lover accounts for his own time and does not treat the woman's wages as the price of meeting him. The effect of this ordinary statement on Champa's face is more concrete than any grand resolution about love.

The thin light of evening at the pond, a paper boat, two leaf-cups of roasted chickpeas, lemon seeds, and laughter produce the chapter's main change of rhythm. Here the water is not a premonition of disaster; it is a refuge of ordinary time chosen under insecure public scrutiny. Champa pays for her own portion, then treats him to jalebi with her own earnings —different sums carry different practical meanings. Both young people discuss the possibility of living in different towns in the future; Champa does not take Amresh's decision about employment into her own hands. The love story does not collapse into a brief marriage proposal; it remains with the uncertainty of choice.

Hours Deducted from Wages: A New Narrative Meaning of "Service"

The school contractor proposes eight hours' work, a voluntary deduction, and payment at the end of the week. Champa counts the sewing required for every bag, the thread, and the time. An advance for three bags is agreed; the remainder of the work is still open. In the shelter's separate register four hours of completed labour have been improperly deducted. Champa does not herself ask to be paid for two hours spent on private medical treatment, but she has the money owed for work actually done entered in the account. Her demand to remove the label "volunteer

attendant" is a visible example of how the language of grants can render labour invisible.

Rukhsana's concern about a depleted budget is not dismissed as villainy beyond argument. Champa accepts reducing the quantity of work, but not disguising a reduction by renaming wages. Ruhani proposes separate columns in the future budget for remuneration and time genuinely contributed voluntarily. In this sequence the narrative places accounting transparency and the pressure of domestic care in the same fictional setting; however, the final audit of an earlier grant is not yet complete. The scene therefore represents limited written correction and an open dispute, not the proposition that "the administration has been fixed."

The Mother's Small Autonomy, Long-Term Repetition, and Artistic Limits

At the time for medicine the mother pours her own water and takes her tablet according to the doctor's instructions. Champa checks the schedule, but placing the medicine directly in her mother's hand does not become an obligatory scene. Later the mother makes a small pouch for needles, complete with crooked stitches. Although this object signifies Champa's professional work, it is also the mother's own active contribution. The new week's schedule opens different hours on Monday, Wednesday, Tuesday, Saturday, Thursday, and Sunday. Sunday evening reserved for individual desire becomes a critical supplement to the time of earning a living, not money owed by anyone.

The final pond scene counter-images the hospital's rigid time. In the first scene there were two doses and uncertain wages; by the last the medicines are at home and the advance for three bags has been received. Nevertheless, Amresh's place of training, the mother's long-term treatment, the next cost of medicines, and the company's proposal to store private information on its server remain undecided. The chapter's particular achievement is that it does not permit the obligations of care to swallow a woman's entire personal life. The risk is that the characters too often utter exemplary maxims about rights. The unforced scene of chickpeas, seeds, and syrup offers an independent experience of feeling.

Chapter 175 — Kabir's Letter

A Jammed Drawer, an Unsent Address, and a Disturbance in the Time of Grief

The chapter begins with Kabir opening a jammed drawer. Naira's habitual action while alive—turning the key a little backwards—returns in

memory without bringing Naira herself into the present. Inside lie blue thread, a stamp, two envelopes, and a blank sheet. The small objects do not restore the dead person, yet neither are they removed. Kabir writes “For Naira,” although there is no address to which the letter can be sent. From the beginning the communicative outcome of the “letter” is suspended; its task is to give language to the imbalance of time within the living sender.

Kabir's hesitation between “is” and “was” is a particularly fine moment of narrative tense. The fact of death is known, but the grammar of direct address seeks continuity with the earlier relationship. Kabir does not invent new dialogue in Naira's voice and declare it a reliable memory. In Subhadra's kitchen a third glass is not taken out; after a conversation between two people, there is no artificial consolation. The page stained with tea is not replaced. This small refusal to edit—the letter survives together with its stain—is a powerful device for expressing the irreparable residue of grief.

Birth Register and Upbringing Register: A Limited Event of Correcting Rights

News comes from Rama Karan's office that the digital field labelled “family's original identity” has combined two different relationships, birth and upbringing, in a single box. A clerk offers the shortcut of guessing a birthplace to fill the empty field. Kabir refuses: Subhadra's history of bringing him up should be recorded, but no unsupported conclusion about his birth should be fashioned out of it. Ruhani submits a handwritten correction note; Rama makes a provisionally certified copy available. The difference between “upbringing history recorded” and “birth determination completed” is decisive. This scene contains a specific administrative success, not a complete answer to existence.

The proposed Naira memorial fund, free software from a private company, and a requirement to share relationship details raise the question of representative authority over someone no longer present. Kabir does not give explicit consent. Rama adds an option to object to the annual review. At a later meeting it is decided to continue issuing uncontested public copies under the old system, suspend the private contract, and publish an account of the time and expense required by applications. To call this “complete privacy protection implemented” would be wrong. An alternative method for providing useful services remains with a future working group, and the birth entry is unverified.

Naira's Voice and Kabir's Memory: The Narrator's Restraint

In recounting his memories, Kabir acknowledges uncertainty about the hour on a rainy day, the date of a quarrel, and the reason for a silence.

Instead of the convenient "I always understood you," the letter says, "Often I did not understand you." This text questions the reliability of its own act of remembrance. Naira's work is recalled, but no new authoritative voice is created in her place after death. Although the third-person narrator enters Kabir's remorse, the narrator does not bring back Naira's absent consciousness through alleged quotations.

Sarita does not demand details of the letter Kabir keeps in his pocket; Subhadra likewise refuses pressure to tell an unverified story of his birth. The privacy of a personal letter and the evidentiary limits of an upbringing parent's memory are not one and the same thing. The principal incompleteness of grief is existential: a letter may be written, but no answer will arrive. The record may be revised, but Naira will not return. Repeated attention to this asymmetry restrains the novel's own tendency to treat documentary disputes as problems admitting of resolution.

The Towel Seller, the Blanket, and the Unconnected Presence of Different Labours

A weaver selling cloth provides separate figures for the thread, dye, and weaving wages included in the price of a gamchha. Kabir pays the full amount; permission to take her photograph is refused. This woman's narrative role is not merely to awaken Kabir's memory of Naira: she also discloses the economic time of her sale and outstanding payment on a previous consignment. Thus an independent economy continues beyond the central character even within a chapter focused on Kabir's grief. He recalls Naira's former teaching that a worker should first be offered water, but does not treat that memory as full forgiveness for his own moral failings.

A neighbour's stitches on Subhadra's old blanket present the multiple contributions involved in upbringing. Kabir shows Subhadra the revised copy; she reads the correct pronunciation of her name, but says that the paper did not create the labour of caring for him in the first place. Objects, labour, and recognition belong to different temporal sequences. Finally Kabir marks the letter "For Naira, unsent" and keeps it in a chest separate from the blanket. One object belongs to the time of upbringing; the other to a world of words spoken in love after death. Neither replaces the other.

The Incompletion of the Ending and the Narrative Sequence of the Next Morning

The public meeting succeeds in preserving certain uncontested services and halting the private contract, but the future register of the Naira memorial fund, the incomplete birth record, and the status of the personal letter as something to be read remain open. On the final veranda Sarita looks after

the key to her school. Kabir offers to wake her; Sarita declines. For the reader, "wake" is an ordinary offer of assistance, but it also introduces the dawn scene in the next chapter. The narrative skill is to leave grief after death not at a grand conclusion but in the subtle preparation for the following day's work.

The artistic limitation is that nearly every documentary turn comes with an exceedingly explicit explanation by a character; the dangers of the private company's contract may become a didactic revelation rather than a discovery made by the reader. Yet the letter's faltering language, the vacant place of a glass, the tea stain, and half-remembered moments without names preserve an experience of unfinished life outside these statements of policy. The chapter does not promise a reply to a mourning letter simply by naming itself after that letter; ultimately the fact that it remains "unsent" is its precise formal closure.

Chapter 176 — Sarita's Dawn

The Third Glass, the Skin on the Milk, and Death Returning to the Body

The chapter begins by Sarita's hearth before dawn. Pain in her knees, rising by supporting herself with her left hand, fingers automatically reaching toward a third glass, and milk boiling over—these objects and bodily actions narrate Naira's absence. Not a long speech of lamentation, but pain in the wrist and the everyday sequence of utensils determine the rhythm of grief. Sarita already knows that Naira has died, yet every morning her body experiences this knowledge afresh. "Dawn" in the title is therefore more than a marker of time; it is a new beginning of the body each day against repetition.

Whether to put a blue shawl on the vacant chair, how the day's work resembles a command she has given herself, and how an earlier sound of her daughter's voice returns in her body's habits: from these small choices the narrator creates intimate access to the character's inward life. The narrator enters Sarita's mind but makes no attempt to reverse Naira's death in the time of the scene through a rebirth. The milk seller in the lane and a girl carrying a bag continue according to their own schedules; the world has not stopped at the moment of death. Because of this harsh inequality, Sarita's refuge is not in inert objects but in her limited ability to choose her own pace.

Opening the Gate and the Social Time of the Shared Reading Room

At the school gate Ramsakhi offers to take the key. Sarita shares the duty of opening the outer gate, while retaining responsibility for the inner

register. Ramsakhi's joke about her broom keeps the scene from acquiring the solemn weight of a royal statute. Sarita's laughter does not signify forgetting her daughter. Ishaan's former study room is now a shared reading room, with open bookshelves, low seats for children, and a broken window catch. While gathering windblown pages, Sarita schedules Maithili's lecture separately from the children's drawing programme. Different kinds of readers can be present along the same wall.

The story's time at eight o'clock with nine children becomes a fine-grained classroom scene. Sarita sits with Mayank in the small task of wiping away wet footprints. Reading a public map of the water routes, one child points out that the government copy does not show a footpath by the pond. Sarita schedules a check rather than immediately declaring the map false. This lesson in "reading a map" also creates awareness of the book's own artistic method: the partial disagreement between an available copy and experience of moving over the ground calls for further examination. The reading room is neither merely a memorial nor the end of inquiry, but an open place for knowledge kept in use.

A Child's Question: The Dead Person's Name and a Refusal of Replacement

Mayank asks about Naira, and then when she will return. Sarita states her death in clear words. The child's next question—who will complete the map?—is a significant displacement, from news of death toward future collective work, without denying the truth of the deceased person's absence. Sarita recognises that children and knowledgeable villagers can carry the work forward, but says that no one will become Naira in Naira's place. The answer imagines neither replacing grief nor turning Naira's work into a rigid object of worship. The original text here keeps death's actual irreversibility distinct from the genuine possibility of succession in work.

At the end of the class Sarita sees a glue mark and begins to scratch it away, then stops. Not every mark must be removed immediately, and not every mark must become a memorial. Two girls share a book, but who qualifies for an assistance list requires separate scrutiny. Visual perception and institutional time do not move at the same speed in this coexistence. Children can share a book immediately; the school's decision about entitlements takes its own time. This distinction is an especially valuable and critically distinctive feature of the chapter's educational setting.

A New Distribution of Duties Under Names and the Uncertainty of Scholarships

In Padma's annual review file, Naira is entered as the "main contact." Sarita wishes to keep the date of death correctly recorded without erasing the previous credit for the work. She limits her own duties to the gate, books, and attendance; she assigns measurement of construction and the legal examination of bills to the engineer. Changing the name is not one person replacing a dead daughter, but a distribution of the times and responsibilities of work. This institutional scene extends the chapter's domestic dawn: the movement of taking up a key at home and the limits upon accepting responsibility at school are both acts of choice by the character.

A proposal for a free digital page called the "Naira Memorial Assistance Centre" seeks to incorporate letters, family photographs, and scholarship eligibility into one private repository. Sarita does not object to providing assistance in the dead person's name; she keeps private letters, unverified information about Kabir's birth, and consent for photographs of minors separate. Written answers are requested about the representative's fees for subsequent years and the opaque method of calculating eligibility; no immediate contract is signed. A scholarship applicant from a family newly displaced by flooding does not appear on the list. Here the story shows that even a sensitive memorial initiative can inadvertently exclude people on the basis of older proof-of-residence documents. The woman receives only a written acknowledgment, not the ultimate benefit.

Three Days of Labour and the Taste of Home: Reality Beyond Grief

Ramsakhi questions the anonymous "volunteer" category covering women's work cleaning the pond. Sarita separates actual daily wages, voluntary time, equipment hire, and donations into different heads. At the school, the contractor's bill shows only two days for Ramsakhi's three days of additional cleaning. Sarita insists that payment for the two undisputed days not be withheld while writing down a date to investigate the third. In these two scenes Ramsakhi is not merely a companion who reduces Sarita's grief, but an independent character with a voice concerning her own labour and dues. The social plot here acquires a momentum independent of domestic sorrow.

The bottle gourd served at a meal and the absent fried potatoes, the changed position of the salt in the kitchen, and Savitri's tempering of cumin are not announcements of a theme, but countless small transformations of time after death through taste and smell. The kitchen becomes a distant echo of "the kitchen of the dead" in the first chapter. Earlier, a living Sarita had been officially declared dead; now, without

Naira, who really is dead, the living mother prepares food at dawn each day. The two circumstances of death are not identical; nevertheless, the narrative importance of everyday domestic action returns here on a new and more bereft temporal plane.

Savitri's Fair and the Final Dawn: A Provisional Form of Consent

Savitri comes to Sarita carrying her medical prescription, but everyone has laughed at her wish to attend the fair. Sarita listens, leaving the prescription in Savitri's own sight. When Champa arrives, her mother states the travel decision in her own words. The route and a place to sit will be checked; if she tires halfway, she can return. The earlier question of autonomy in old age within Ashramavasika Parva thus recurs in a modern wish to travel, without literally repeating any ancient scene. The journey is still a plan, not a completed visit to the fair.

On the final night Naira's old attendance sheet is not struck through; Sarita's current duties are entered on a new work list. The third glass at home is neither turned into an object of daily worship nor forcibly removed. In the final scene at the following dawn, Sarita takes her own medicine, puts water on to heat, and picks up the school's key. The chapter is circular, from dawn to dawn, but its beginning and ending are not the same moment. The intervening school, the child's question, outstanding payments for work, and Savitri's choice have brought real changes into Sarita's day. Its artistic limitation is the repetition of didactic propositions; its achievement is to show a changing rhythm of working with grief without inventing a false story that suffering has ended.

Ashramavasika Parva / Uttara Kanda — Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 173–176

Relationships Cannot Be Contained in an Image: The Four Narrative Lines

The first four chapters of Ashramavasika Parva showed the freedom of ageing bodies to move, the reorganisation of the library, and the limits of authority within families. Chapters 173–176 concentrate on the question, “How does life continue after institutional corrections have been made?” Maithili's credit has been reprinted, but a decision about living together in marriage is separate; Champa's mother has received a prescription, but the cost of treatment cuts into the daughter's work; Kabir's record of upbringing has been corrected, but Naira's death and the uncertain question of his birth remain; Sarita receives the school's key but cannot replace her daughter with any human task. What unites the four chapters

is not one common maxim of policy, but the unfolding of lived everyday time after incomplete corrections.

Their four opening scenes—two keys, a blurred prescription, a jammed drawer, and a third glass—use different narrative devices. The keys may be read as the authority to open, the prescription as a practical difficulty in treatment, the drawer as memory that has not been sent, and the glass as absence after death. Their meanings do not amount to a uniform sermon on "paper versus life"; each device works differently through a character's material circumstances. The scenes are explicitly located in modern Videhapur in 2040; these four chapters lack a direct successive sequence from the ancient epic. Thus the earlier dual-period structure of Ashramavasika Parva is carried in this section by memory and the modern narrative.

Narrative Duration, Analepsis, and the Recurrence of Dawn

Chapter 173 follows more than one day, a public programme, a correction in the newspaper, and Champa's arrival the following morning. In 174 time stretches from the urgent hospital sequence to a weekly work schedule; the quiet pond scene gives a different felt duration to measured hours of labour. In 175 a letter being written is placed among several days of office business, domestic remembrance, and a public meeting; uncertainty over the date of an old quarrel itself demonstrates the limitations of the remembering narrator. In 176 the circular form from dawn to the following dawn is more concentrated. In view of these differences, narrative duration is not equal: the density of a state of mind that interrupts action in Kabir's letter, the different hours of earnings in Champa's accounts, and bodily repetition in Sarita's routine are more significant.

Analepsis also occurs in four forms: Maithili's rainy evening of shared study, Champa's fear born of an old private message becoming public, Kabir's incomplete memories of Naira, and Sarita's blue shawl and Naira's work with children. These memories are neither facts of identical evidentiary standing nor automatic commands governing present decisions. Maithili remains separate even as she acknowledges the old happiness; Champa chooses to visit the pond despite fear from a stained public experience; Kabir refrains from writing an imaginary response from Naira; Sarita keeps an open reading room instead of a shrine. Such different behavioural responses to memory release the characters' inner lives from the necessity of one outcome.

The Distribution of Voices: The Gap Between Public Titles and Private Speech

In 173 the organiser's heading "reunion" is a false public imitation of Maithili's actual decision. In 174 the word "volunteer" conceals Champa's remunerated labour. In 175 the digital box "family's original identity" confuses the separate relations of birth and upbringing. In 176 the attractive name "Naira Memorial Assistance Centre" seeks to hide a private letter repository and an opaque classification for scholarships. In all four cases the act of naming creates an authoritative account separate from the event. To resist it, characters first examine its written form and then record an objection. Records and publicity operate like competing narrators inside the story, but none possesses omniscience.

Rukhsana, Rajan, Sarita, the mother herself, Amresh, Subhadra, Ramsakhi, Mayank, Padma, Rama, and the widow displaced by flooding bring their separate needs to bear upon the leading characters' decisions. If every voice only reiterated the same ethical conclusion, the claim to polyphony would be weak. The especially effective moments are those in which a character's social time remains independent: Ramsakhi's wages for a third day, Champa's advance, Rajan's expenditure on flowers, the correct pronunciation of Subhadra's name, Mayank's question about who will complete the map, and the displaced widow's unresolved scholarship. None is dependent solely on defending one person's way of life.

Completed Achievements, Open Investigations, and the Uncrossable Distance of Grief

In 173 a corrected programme, a bounded public reading, a separate tenancy receipt, and a practical boundary allowing only specific contact by letter are achieved; the newspaper prints a small correction, but the reach of the earlier report is unknown, and actual payment for Sarita's copying remains open. In 174 a medical examination, new prescription, purchase of medicine, some correction of recorded work hours, and an advance for three bags are accomplished; future treatment costs, an old grant audit, and the proposal for a private information server remain open. In 175 a provisional certified copy naming the person who raised Kabir is issued and the company's private contract is stopped; the question of birth is unverified, and the letter to Naira remains unsent. In 176 Sarita assumes part of the school's work and an inquiry into an incorrect names list is scheduled; no private repository contract is signed, Ramsakhi's third day's pay is disputed, and Savitri's trip to the fair remains undecided.

This inventory of results is essential because, in this novel, "consent," "receipt," "provisional copy," "correction," and "payment in full" are not synonyms. Even in the context of bereavement, correcting a name is

different from undoing a loss; no alteration of a register can reverse Naira's death. The narrative constructs new roles for those alive; it does not turn the dead person into a magical respondent. Because of this distinction, the account of modern institutions and the narrative of private grief run together without swallowing each other.

Critical Judgment and Tests for the Remaining Parva

The artistic force of these four chapters lies in the recurrence of small objects. Maithili's water pot, the mother's medicine box, Kabir's gamchha, blanket, and envelope, and Sarita's third glass each give language to labour, memory, or autonomy from an earlier life. Kabir's unsent letter and Sarita's hearth in particular express the experience of an incomplete relationship without needing an explicit speech. There is a contradiction as well: the characters' exchanges about rights, payment, and personal consent are sometimes remarkably harmonious and mature; there could have been more silence within the scenes, allowing readers to infer more independently. It would therefore be wrong to describe the narrative construction as flawless.

The next four chapters, 177–180, must be tested against their actual text. The headings concerning an elder's consent, Vidura's path, private forgiveness, and outside the shelter are merely anticipatory guides for study. A pattern found so far is not the inevitable conclusion of the rest of the parva. If the text presents unusual disagreement, failure, or a new narrative technique, the assessment must be tested anew.

Chapter 177 — The Elder’s Consent

Three Routes to the Fair: A Visual Opening for the Right to Decide

At the outset Champa inspects the worn rubber tip of her mother's walking stick, and Savitri asks whether this repair is merely a pretext for keeping her away from the fair. This domestic irony immediately opens two distinct purposes: ensuring a safe journey, and safeguarding an older person's right to make her own decision about that journey. Three alternatives have been written out on the veranda: the main road, the route behind the pond, and remaining at home while someone brings back pictures. Yet the third alternative produces a genuine narrative discomfort: “Who will choose for me?” The list supplies information; it does not create desire.

Savitri's wish does not remain an unchanging obstinacy after she has declared it once. Seeing the crowd at the gate, she chooses the rear path with benches; when her knee tires, she decides to leave the song unfinished and return; the next morning she speaks of resting. Through this sequence

the chapter distinguishes a change of mind from the confiscation of someone's choice. In place of the numerical achievement of seeing the entire fair, it examines narratively how far a person can control the time available to her body. The unfinished song signifies not defeat but a chosen pause.

The Walking Stick, the Lamp, and Wages: The Separate Movements of Objects and Memory

Champa's work inspecting seven bags, Rukhsana's additional kitchen shift, and Anup's hours at the tool workshop accompany the journey as parallel events. To prevent women's care work from becoming an obligatory, unpaid service, the narrative specifies working hours, transferred responsibilities, and a separate wage slip. Champa accepts membership of the advisory group only on the condition that the time required and travelling expenses are declared. Ramsakhi intervenes to question the disappearance of women's labour both in domestic care and in public service. The story brings ideal statements of rights down to concrete terms of income.

Savitri's five-rupee earthen lamp is an important object of memory. A folk song recalls the first fair after her marriage, when her mother told her to buy something of her own choosing, but she could buy nothing. After this brief analepsis, purchasing a little lamp in the present enters into dialogue with a desire left unfulfilled earlier in life. If the lamp is treated merely as a "symbol of freedom," the potter's stall, the actual price, and the older body's fatigue lose their local significance. Savitri sings two unfinished lines to Sarita: memory survives in a living voice rather than in a complete paper record.

The Consent Form: The Language of Assistance versus the Language of Life

At the bus stand an employee demands a full account of illnesses in order to provide facilities for older people; inspection of the rule shows that a general declaration of age and difficulty walking would have sufficed. At the help pavilion near the entrance, the expression "principal caregiver" conceals broad consent concerning treatment, changes of residence, and receipt of money. These two documents, uncovered in sequence, show attempts to make an elderly person's voice the invisible price of convenience. Savitri has the scope restricted in writing to "today's journey only"; Rama questions the provision of a personal copy and the means of withdrawing consent. Her objection is received, but the immediately desired facility is not supplied. That outcome remains unresolved in its own right.

The elderly tenant's narrative is not merely a repetition of Savitri's situation. Her roof leaks; she is willing to accept temporary accommodation for three nights, but not to surrender her right to a permanent home. Champa reaches for the paper, whereupon the tenant first asks who she is and folds it again; she hands it over herself when Rama arrives. This tiny interruption shows the reader that general sympathy does not in itself confer a right to read another person's private letter. The tenant's written conditions are read at the evening meeting; in the landlord's absence, the matter remains "under consideration."

Editing Across Two Times and the Limits of Focalisation

After the extended modern fair scene comes a short episode in an ancient hermitage: a bamboo staff falls. Sanjaya moves at once to pick it up, but Dhritarashtra first asks where it has fallen, reaches for it himself, and explicitly requests assistance only after failing. It would be inappropriate to regard this as a direct historical instance of the modern consent form; the two scenes concern different times, persons, and circumstances. By placing them consecutively, however, the narrator brings the delicate distance between an older person's acceptance of help and the erasure of that person's voice into the reader's experience. Kunti's forthcoming inspection of the grain measure extends this perspective to communal distribution.

The third-person narration does not subordinate Savitri's present decision to Champa's fear for her safety. At one point the narrator explicitly says that Champa's assumption that her mother would have to be restrained proved mistaken; the correction of this prior belief opens focalisation towards Savitri's experience. Nevertheless, Rama, Padma, Ramsakhi, and Champa repeatedly articulate subtle distinctions of rights in carefully organised sentences. Such repetition increases the narrative's policy transparency, but somewhat restricts the unconfined sensory experience of the fair. The song, the crowd, and the lamp offer a little unexplained time that counterbalances this didactic density.

The Difference between Completed Events and Unfulfilled Promises

Savitri does visit the fair, change her route, lodge an objection about limited assistance, buy a lamp, and return before the event ends; Champa accepts a time-limited membership of the group. The elderly tenant's roof has not been repaired; a group has only been selected to consider changing the rules; and a lasting rule excluding sweeping medical authorisation remains to be made. Precisely because these achievements are uneven, the chapter is ultimately not a solution to every problem of older people's welfare, but a difficult exercise in protecting the right to decide. The lamp beside the window the following morning is less an ornament of happiness than a tangible record of Savitri arranging the order of her own day.

Chapter 178 — Vidura’s Path

From the Ancient Forest to the Modern Meeting Room: A Clear Arrangement of Two Narrative Times

The chapter opens with dew upon Vidura's sandals in the ancient hermitage. His question about the path heading north encounters Dhritarashtra's question about “sitting down and talking”; departure into the forest thereby becomes more than a change of location. It becomes the decision to live apart from the minister's old relations of authority. Even without a throne, Vidura might still constitute a “court.” Gandhari objects that announcing his own departure must not become another unilateral decision imposed on someone else. The narrator does not automatically glorify renunciation as innocent.

Stones set in place to protect the hermitage have diverted a forest-dwelling woman's drainage channel. Sanjaya fears that the elderly residents may slip; the woman asks for water to reach her house; Vidura calls for both routes to be measured. Within two hours the stones are moved, a support for holding on is installed, and the water returns to the path of the hut. The woman refuses Vidura's offer to pay for the work with a ring bearing the royal seal: labour and the right to water are not gifts from a royal family. A child's boat and wooden bird reveal the small physical alteration on the living scale of local life.

The Archival Key and the Institution's Aspiration to Omniscience

The scene cuts to Videhapur in 2040. An old brass lock lies in a school meeting room, and a review committee seeks permanent authority to collect documents, grant private permissions, and issue final decisions on complaints. Rama sets out three separate headings: “hearing,” “recommendation,” and “decision.” A printing company points to the lower cost of fewer compartments; Sarita, looking at the old lock and new key, identifies the danger of renaming a monopoly without changing it. This is not the literal rebirth of the ancient royal court. The sequence places the structural correspondences between administrative power in the two periods before the reader.

Savitri comes in person to describe her limited consent for the fair visit. The elderly tenant sends a written demand concerning the key to her own home and the time when she may return. Phulmati wants room for dissent in decisions about collective net-making work; Nandini insists that supplying water measurements should not be construed as surrendering land rights. These voices originate in different interests and locations. The concrete basis for evaluating the chapter's polyphony is whose time the

committee's speed saves and whom it leaves behind, not merely the fact that many people speak.

Visible Silence, Accessibility, and Outstanding Dues

A hearing-impaired elderly member introduces an unexpected narrative intervention. While everyone is discussing the value of debate within fixed time limits, it emerges that this member never received the minutes of the last two meetings in an accessible form. The episode thus limits the previous claim to an "open meeting" from within. A decision is made to budget separately for written notices, copies to be read aloud, and sign-language support. The physical arrangement of accessible communication enters the narrative's very structure of voicing: who has the means to speak and to be heard?

Before the vote Sarita reads out incomplete facts: the tenant's roof still leaks; payment for Champa's two hours has not reached her bank; Phulmati has not received the market document for the net-making group. Even on the final page Champa's entry says "order issued," not "payment completed." Phulmati herself publicly corrects an entry wrongly saying "share of the boat" to "share of the net." This minuscule linguistic alteration becomes the first real test of the entire institutional reform. The story's resolution is not the passage of a governmental draft, but keeping open the route by which mistakes may be corrected.

Vidura's Departure, the Empty Seat, and the Burden of the Past

In the final forest-hermitage scene Vidura informs Dhritarashtra, Gandhari, and Sanjaya of his departure, but explicitly preserves his right to correct his own statements. He neither throws the old royal ring into the river nor buries it in the soil; he puts it in an inner pocket of his bag. Rather than the dazzling disposal associated with renunciation, a remnant of unfinished responsibility survives. No one immediately sits in the vacated place: that interval makes the uneasy emptiness of a transfer of authority part of the narrative rhythm. In the modern period Ishaan writes a line relinquishing permanent personal ownership of his name attached to an old proposal. The small internal actions in both times show the difficult difference between abandonment and correction.

The narrator describes the modern committee's revised draft at length: a rotating six-month composition, direct representation, limited use of private documents, and an independent appeal mechanism. The dissent of two members is retained in the minutes. This formal transparency shows the reader the limits of what has actually been decided, but almost every speaker in a single chapter handles administrative subtleties with extraordinary clarity. The forest woman's obstructed watercourse and the

hearing-impaired member's enforced silence connect this conceptual dialogue with material delays in people's lives.

Foreshadowing the Question of Forgiveness and an Assessment

By the final morning, the old lock has been placed among objects of historical interest. On the public noticeboard appears the question: after dissent has been heard, who has the right to grant personal forgiveness? Sarita leaves it unanswered. This explicit anticipation opens the subject of personal forgiveness in the following chapter, but does not leave the outcome of Vidura's Path unresolved: the departure takes place, the committee's structure is changed, and the public register of corrections begins to operate. The meeting point of limited accomplishment and a new question is the chapter's principal narrative achievement.

Chapter 179 — Personal Forgiveness

The Cracked Measure: The Story of Diminished Grain Before the Request for Forgiveness

In the forest hermitage the grain measure is cracked at the bottom; Suvasa, an attendant, has received less than her portion. Dhritarashtra almost orders a replacement from the royal granary, but stops to ask who has authority over the hermitage store. Two days of blank entries are found in the ledger. The cracked measure and the failure to record are distinct events. Suvasa brings up the history of her son, killed in the war and wrongly named in the records, while making clear that reduced grain rations and the memory of her son are not the same matter. From its opening, the narrative establishes different durations for private injury and concrete economic redress.

Dhritarashtra asks, “Could you forgive me?” Suvasa replies, “Not yet,” and asks for assurance that the answer will not reduce her food allocation. There is no performance of defeat in this moment; the wish of the person asking forgiveness and the refusal of the person harmed inhabit the same scene. Compensation for two days' missing grain arrives, with examination of the remaining records deferred until the next morning. Gandhari's anger, too, persists without bringing the service to a halt. The episode's emotional density lies less in a declaration of “no forgiveness” than in Suvasa's ordinary work of spreading out her clothes and Gandhari's rising and leaving after refusing an entreaty.

Three Tables and the Other Person's Voice: The Editing of the Modern Narrative

The modern sequence begins with a rain-soaked notice on which the word “forgiveness” has run in the ink. On a new sheet Sarita writes the individual's right to forgive separately from the continuing processes of appeals, outstanding dues, and investigation. At the school, three different tables are provided for private statements, documentary examination, and payment. This spatial arrangement gives moral debate a narrative structure: a public apology is not a sum paid, nor is a corrected objection an emotional reconciliation. The printing company adds a line to the end of the apology form treating previous disputes as settled; Padma blocks it.

Savitri seeks correction of her objection, but does not regard hearing the young man's apology as handing over to him the power to decide. Champa's bank receipt remains empty; the company's representative cannot pay the wages due for her committee work by apologising. This moment reactivates the incompleteness of “order issued” from the previous chapter. Rather than simply repeating an emotional drama, the characters display the limits of different forms of utterance: supplication, legal drafting, a bank entry, and personal experience.

The Nomadic Narrative: A Collective Demand and Separate Journeys

The arrival of Gauri Kapariya, Reva Gulgulia, Janki, and other nomadic groups broadens the chapter's canvas. An official list has converted departure from an unsafe railway verge into “the group voluntarily vacated the site.” Gauri accepts the evacuation of dangerous ground, not abandonment of a permanent claim. An official annexure clarifies the difference between the actual limits of a red hazard marking and an unmeasured extension of that line. A corrected measurement is not mistaken for complete rehabilitation. A list of safe temporary sites is promised within three days; a third party's claim over the warehouse grounds remains unaffected.

Gauri's joint alliance has three aims: emergency stopping places, eviction notices, and routes to education and treatment. Yet the personal journeys of Gauri, Reva, and Janki remain different. Reva will stay until her daughter's examination, Janki will decide according to Sarayu's health, and Gauri will explore tarpaulin work at the southern market. Gauri does not let her leadership turn into sovereign authorisation over the lives of every nomadic family. Within this polyphony, “nomadic” is a social classification, not a collective character possessing one identical desire.

Naira's Absence, Kabir's Words, and the Limits of Memory

Sarita corrects the heading of Naira's old private assistance letter: private support is not official certification. After Naira's death, Sarita's grief cannot become grounds for suspending investigation; the old technical file concerning Aniruddha remains open until the next hearing. On the other hand, Sarita wishes to decide for herself when to hear a personal apology. Mourning and administrative process are not opposites, but matters governed by different times.

While hammering a broken wooden board into place, Kabir tells a girl that some parts of a wrong can be put right, some losses cannot be reversed, and he cannot write the answer of the person who was hurt. The scene is more concentrated than the meeting's abstract principles, because the repair of a loose nail and the irreparable absence of a dead relationship coexist. In the conversation between the students Maithili and Ishaan, pressure to forgive is likewise rejected, but their language is explanatory. Kabir's visible task makes the narrator's concept more credible as an act.

Incomplete Resolution, Narrative Duration, and Critical Limits

The chapter is constructed through cuts between several places: the grain measure in the forest hermitage, the school in Videhapur, a public hearing of nomadic groups, relations between hospital and shelter, and then Suvasa's new morning. In the final hermitage scene Suvasa requests a copy of the ledger: evidence is available for only one of the two disputed days of measurement, not the other. Dhritarashtra does not repeat his request for forgiveness. In the modern final scene there is no public list naming those who have accepted an apology; only a corrected eviction notice, the limited alliance, and the appeal date are posted.

Artistically, the cracked measure, the rain-blurred word “forgiveness,” the bundle of tarpaulins, and Kabir's wooden board form four independent chains of objects. Making all of them one metaphor for a grand theory of justice would erase their local specificity. The chapter succeeds by joining their differences within a common narrative; its limitation is that numerous characters offer excessively explicit ethical classifications, making some dialogue resemble meeting minutes. Suvasa's unwavering “Not yet,” however, leaves the reader with the discomfort of a decision that belongs to someone else.

Chapter 180 — Outside the Shelter

The Knot in a Mat and Twelve Beds: Grant-Funded Numbers versus the Circumstances of Life

The semicircular bamboo rib of a mat made by Hiravati Kurariyar trembles in the wind. Inside the shelter stand twelve beds; outside lie her tools and a half-stitched mat. In this opening image, the mobility of working life confronts the stillness of the shelter building. To obtain a grant, the register has combined use of a workplace, two nights' emergency refuge, and permanent residence in a single "housing beneficiary" entry. Hiravati says that a receipt for work is not an application for residence. Ruhani draws a red line through the incorrect count without tearing out the page. The story refuses the illusion of a purified beginning created by erasing the history of an erroneous record.

Rukhsana says she is prepared to count food plates, not to make every person who eats fill out a questionnaire about an entire life. Beneath "voluntarily accepted shelter," Champa's form contains a condition waiving future claims to permanent rehabilitation. The story exposes the trap of turning distinct moments of service into permanent bonds. Ruhani, formerly the shelter's administrator, relinquishes a number convenient to her institution and develops a new classification of the needs of people living outside it.

Sarayu's Voice and the Recurrent Time of Assistance

Sarayu has been listed as a permanent resident because she stayed two nights; she wants to return to her daughter. Ruhani asks four different questions: where she will stay today, how her treatment contact will be maintained, what should remain confidential, and when she wishes to be asked again. In the middle of this, Sarayu asks for water; the haste of paperwork cannot override the body's pause. Narrative duration expands here: instead of a single permanent box in a form, it admits life decisions capable of changing from day to day. The employee's convenience decreases; the character's voice grows.

At the end Sarayu prepares to go to her daughter; Janki does not sign a form releasing the house. Ruhani supplies the arrangements for getting help again in an emergency and a copy of the written conditions governing overnight stays. The plot's success lies not in keeping Sarayu inside the shelter, but in preserving her right to return after leaving the institution. The possibility of "coming back" opens up, in temporal terms, the earlier rigid category of "housing beneficiary."

Chandra's Song, Hiravati's Measurement, and the Tensions of the Festival

The municipal festival committee proposes using the shelter's emergency beds for performers and offers "a stage in the public interest" in place of wages. Chandra Badi is confronted with a collective agreement supposedly covering "all women performers" merely because of the name of her community. She has her singing, rhythm instruction, duration, rest, recording rights, and travel charges written separately. Half the payment for an earlier folk performance remains due, so the new contract is not concluded. Hiravati asks why making a mat is paid as a thing while singing a song is regarded merely as a service. This is the chapter's theatrical popular rejoinder. The illusion that a caste name automatically grants control of an individual's decisions breaks down.

Hiravati receives specified hours for one week on a safe temporary veranda; the old condition demanding unpaid watch duty in exchange is removed. She takes an advance from a customer and buys new bamboo, although her claim to a permanent house plot remains held up in municipal examination. The narrative delicately opens the contradiction between a mobile place to work and security in a settled home. A customer's receipt does not become a public list of names. Chandra's incorrect poster is stopped and a corrected identification printed, but bank confirmation of her arrears and final agreement about the stage remain outstanding.

Aruna's Water in Antiquity: The Concluding Structure of Ashramavasika Parva

In the forest hermitage Aruna works in the communal kitchen, but wishes to spend her nights in her own house, which needs repairs. The hermitage platform blocks the drainage channel outside her home. Kunti, Sanjaya, Aruna, and the workers measure the slope and move the bamboo. The storehouse veranda must be made smaller, but water again flows along its old course. Dhritarashtra comes to Aruna's doorway and acknowledges his previous habit of issuing commands in the name of "everyone's welfare." Aruna does not make his self-criticism the final centre of her life: she needs drainage and an account of the bamboo. This response preserves the ancient scene's independent narrative authority.

The apparent similarity between the names of the ancient hermitage and the modern shelter is attractive, but the real narrative connection concerns distinct sequences of events about physical dwelling, drainage, labour, and the rights of those regarded as without shelter. The ancient scene reaches completion through its own decision. At the modern close Ruhani posts separate hearing arrangements for those "coming inside, staying outside, and returning again." Bamboo prepared for the

forthcoming Yadava festival is reflected in the pond, but has not yet been erected. This image opens a narrative doorway from the ending of one parva to the beginning of the next.

Conclusion: The Limits of the Service Institution and the Critical Tension of Form

Rights to a home, a temporary workplace, emergency food, treatment, and a stage for folk art require different physical spaces in this chapter. Ruhani's declaration that her bunch of keys cannot lock anyone's entire future is a governing proposition of the narrative arrangement. Yet frequent explicit repetition of this principle sometimes resolves the characters' dilemmas too promptly. Hiravati's mat, Aruna's blocked channel, Sarayu's rest, and Chandra's ankle bells are denser narrative objects: their incomplete scenes leave the reader room to think. Ashramavasika Parva ends here, while the inquiry into permanent housing, earlier dues to the performer, and the actual grant shortfall remain outstanding.

MAUSALA PARVA / UTTARA KANDA

Chapter 181 — The Yadavas' Festival

The Brass Wheel and the Double Groove: The First Difference within the Spectacle of Victory

The modern festival opens with a bright brass wheel rolling across the ground. On one side is a decorative wheel bearing the donor company's name; on the other is a load-bearing coupling with a double groove made by Sumitra Kami. The measurement sheet records the price of the decorative object but leaves the maker of the useful coupling unnamed. This pairing of objects is a miniature of the conflict to come: the visibility of prestige and the invisibility of labour that ensures safety. The proposed map of the festival ground likewise treats the site as vacant land, although Rukhsana's temporary stall, the children's play area, and the veranda used by Hiravati's customers are already there.

The chairperson wants people to celebrate without objections after a difficult year. Before dismissing that desire, the narrator places behind the chairperson's speech workers lifting bamboo in a waterlogged pit, although no wage rates have been set down for them in writing. This layered scene carries the reader's attention from the front of the stage to the labour behind it. The distance between the discourse of enjoyment and the bodies that produce the occasion of enjoyment becomes a narrative event, not a fixed moral lesson.

The Landing at Dvaraka: The Ancient Time of Victory and Its Distinct Rights

In ancient Dvaraka, amid conches and a procession of dynastic chariots, the water-carrying girl's pot is spilling and the boatmen's access to the landing has narrowed. Krishna's first act is not simply to remove a guard: he asks why the owners of ceremonial trading boats have appropriated the landing during the afternoon. Balarama raises the question of equality between the royal house's heroism and the bodily labour of boatmen. The boatmen do not demand a single common victory cry; they ask for time in which to move by water. Here the ancient story is richer than a resemblance to a modern map, present in its own arrangements for water and its own political arrogance.

After Krishna's practical decision to open the ceremonial route, he does not assume that the princes' anger has disappeared. The girl takes water home and a new duty roster is established, but discontent within the ruling lineage remains. The ancient festival thus becomes not a mechanical, certain prophecy of the devastation to come in Mausala Parva, but an intense present configuration of power.

Credit for a Metal Coupling: An Inner Story of Festival Materials

The date on Sumitra's earlier design and the festival contractor's register of a purportedly new experiment contradict each other. Nazir Sikligar makes a technical comparison of the inner groove, the grip of the rope, and similarities in load-testing; the later date of the specimen, however, does not establish a fully formed intention to steal. Sumitra limits her claim to the use demonstrably made of her work and the safety of the stage. When a component rotates during testing, construction on that part of the stage stops. The narrative crisis changes here from a verbal dispute about rights and credit into a direct danger to bodies.

Sumitra refuses an offer of “honorary recognition” in exchange for declaring her design dispute closed. A new manufacturing draft separately records her share in the design, Chhotelal's wages for grinding, Nazir's inspection fee, and insurance against risk; the older allegation stays in an independent file. Sumitra receives an advance testing allowance, not her entire prospective share of production earnings. A half-empty stage may look like the failure of a festival, but the preservation of a safe place for children to play is the real value of that formal emptiness.

Kitchen, Song, and Recording Rights: Multiple Voices

Rather than have meals for thirty volunteers regarded as free “community assistance,” Rukhsana wants the price of grain, fuel, and work written down. Chandra Badi insists on separate permission for a live stage

performance and a digital recording; the organisers initially wanted to turn her entire voice into permanent property. A brief exchange between Chandra and Sumitra reveals the distinction between the right "for everyone to hear" and the right "to sell to everyone." Although they share an interest in fair recognition, their labour is different: one performs with her voice, the other measures objects and tests loads. The narrator does not dissolve them all into a single metaphor of the artist.

Chandra completes her first song performance but stops the sale of a recording from behind the stage. Making rules for an event is one matter in the story; an artist's actual objection at the moment of infringement is another. Confirmation is sought that a locally stored copy has been deleted, while the old digital vendor file remains to be investigated. These distinctions reject the easy assumption that the existence of a contract means everything is in order.

The Trembling Hand on the Final Night: The Next Crisis in the Mausala Sequence

Lamps are lit at the opening; rain washes colour from the rangoli; Chandra's performance and the wage ledger proceed in parallel. Late in the evening a young man's hand trembles beside a brass cup, and the committee wants him removed to avoid bad publicity. Seeing him from a distance, Champa raises the separate questions of assistance for a body in need and investigation of a sales dispute. Ending the chapter at this moment shifts the narrative rhythm from a song of festival triumph to a health emergency.

Accomplishments include a safe platform, an emergency access route, Sumitra's limited production agreement, separate expenditure for food, and Chandra's first performance payment. Unfinished matters include wages in full, the earlier design dispute, the investigation into recording, and the condition of the trembling young man. The novel's stylistic limitation is that almost every character is expert at defining things on paper; yet the sudden arrival of a trembling body disrupts the reader's certainty. This disorderly material and human event makes the opening of Mausala Parva more effective.

Chapter 182 — The Intoxicating Day

The Overturned Cup and Two Narrative Times: An Emergency Scene

The thread of the trembling young man from Chapter 181 immediately becomes a fully developed scene: the cup overturns onto the earth, the drum continues uninterrupted, and Champa kneels down. The uninterrupted festive beat and the instability of Deepak's body establish

two different durations within the narration. Champa makes clear the limits of her skill and calls a trained health worker. She stops people from searching his pockets, displaying his debts on paper for everyone to see, or spreading his name. Focalisation here is not medical omniscience: the story develops through the limited observations of the caregiver present and what the patient himself says.

Deepak, when able to respond, gives his name briefly; his friend Rakesh offers tentative information about previous consumption and fear. The story does not establish the precise substance or a diagnosis from those conjectures. During the journey to hospital, Deepak's informed consent and his limited wish to notify his family remain central. Later a doctor describes possibilities for treatment but offers no immediate guarantee that he can return to work. His future life is not imprisoned within a narrow plot consisting of one oath, one treatment, and one public punishment.

Dvaraka's Second Festival Day: The Pressure of Heroism and the Right to Water

On the second day of the victory festival in ancient Dvaraka, the landing is blocked again, this time by young men drinking liquor and humiliating boatmen by loosening their ropes. Balarama lets a trembling young man rest and challenges collective pressure to drink by taking water himself from an old woman's vessel. Krishna asks what the boatmen have actually experienced and, after the insult, establishes shared rules: the landing shall remain open; nobody shall be forced to drink; care for the unconscious is obligatory. Samba's averted eyes and the fragments of a thrown vessel visibly preserve dissent.

The ancient episode is not the ancestral case history of Deepak's modern medical report; it is a narrative echo. Public force and pressure through collective humiliation dominate in Dvaraka, whereas treatment, livelihood, selling, and privacy constitute distinct storylines in Videhapur. To consider both merely examples of “the harmful effects of drinking” would erase the difference between the boatmen's endangered livelihood, Deepak's undetermined medical condition, and Samba's collective pride. The achievement of the dual-temporal structure lies in keeping these differences intact.

Deepak's Voice and the Public Hunger for a Face

The festival secretary wants to draw a screen and conceal the incident; a journalist demands a photograph; an official wants publicity for a pledge. The narrative arranges these three attempts as competing public accounts, confronted by Deepak's brief “I need help.” Rakesh describes fear of his

mother's reproaches and the possibility of his friend losing work. Deepak telephones his family himself; his mother begins angrily but says she will come in the morning. This short domestic conversation offers not instant forgiveness or miraculous transformation, but the possibility of a relationship unfolding in time.

Confidential records of treatment and the investigation into unlawful sales are placed on separate tracks. Padma distinguishes the timing of what people heard from the timing of what they observed; the police agree to examine public receipts and independent testimony. A company's offer of free counselling asks for promotional details about the patient, and that requirement is removed. Social criticism here becomes a narrative technique: there are several incomplete narrators of one event, and the novel does not immediately elevate anyone's conjecture into final truth.

Suman's Red Dot: A Cut from the Body's Story to the Artwork's Story

In the middle section Suman Tikulhar sees her old design—three lines and a red dot—on the company's new boards. The narrative cuts suddenly from treatment to the question of the use of an artistic pattern. This is not a subsidiary subplot: it reveals the danger of dissolving more than one person's private rights into a single public festival. The printer's cost ledger counts printed copies but leaves the right to use the design blank. Suman does not claim ownership over every circular mark; she specifies the arrangement of lines and the earlier date of her particular design.

An agreement for the next forty boards is made, specifying a limited period, credit, remuneration, and separate permission to reprint; the first advance is received. Compensation for earlier unauthorised copying is not extinguished by this agreement. A girl looks at Suman's pattern and draws a circle with her own hand, using a different arrangement of lines; Suman does not stop her. The distinction between transformative learning and commercial copying receives a visual answer that needs little extended explanation.

From Hospital to Memorial: Foreshadowing an Unfinished Ending

Deepak remains in hospital for further care; his friend Rakesh produces receipts for three earlier nights of labour before the contractor. A due date is recorded, but payment has not been completed. Champa comes back with her injured wrist and sits silently beside her mother without revealing Deepak's name. Her silence is an ethical interval amid the story's noise, while the public programme seeks, through noise, to turn every life into a promotional narrative.

The final scene introduces a proposal for a permanent memorial with names of the dead, photographs, and exclusive privileges over nearby

commercial signboards. A new image has been drafted for a use extending beyond Suman's limited design consent. Ruhani draws a red line through it and places the matter on the agenda of the next meeting. The chapter about treatment for substance use does not supply an immediate verdict on the memorial contract: it opens new questions of privacy and commercialisation as narrative matters. The transition is formally successful, though the equally explicit language applied to every subsequent storyline somewhat blunts the sharpness of the characters' natural disagreements.

Chapter 183 — The Memorial Contract

The Phagun Landing and a Blank Advertising Space: A Public Scene of Remembrance

At daybreak during the 2041 festival honouring the landing, Ramsakhi removes algae and finds a water-soaked paper reading "Immortal Memory, Permanent Sponsorship"; behind those words is a space not for the name of the dead, but for an advertisement. This opening makes the commercialisation of remembrance visible before the author declares a position. Sarita places a brick beneath a wobbling chair. This small domestic remedy creates a meaningful contrast with the actual structural instability behind the proposal for a local site of memory.

Displaying a sample of shining stone, Shailaj requests ten-year rights over images, name lists, and shop publicity. Sarita refuses to transfer Naira's private letters, photographs, and name as commercial rights; Ruhani raises the needs of other families who want a place of remembrance. Their public bitterness matters. In earlier chapters, female colleagues often supported one another's conclusions; here two legitimate but incomplete desires collide. Champa's silence between them adds actual duration to the disagreement.

Hands at the Landing and Three Boxes in a Shop: Labour Beneath Memory

Ramsakhi identifies separate costs for sanitation wages, removal of silt, safety for those entering the water, and repairs to broken steps. The company has absorbed these sums into the cost of polished stone. The sister of the deceased Urmila Rajak points to outstanding claims for hospital night shifts, washing at the landing, and carrying laundry. Proposing to engrave the dead Urmila's name on stone does not automatically discharge those debts. The distinction amid real work is critical: the memorial design grows more elaborate while the green marks of algae on the cleaner's hands still speak of work in the present.

Farzana Churihar refuses a proposal to turn her three boxes—lac bangles shaped by hand, pairs of glass bangles, and machine-made bangles—into a costly "sacred" business attached to memory. Customers' independent preferences, sources of materials, and payment must be treated separately. Kamala Jain distinguishes the price of meals from publicity for a private religious rite. Her niece Riddhi's personal dissent remains a real argument within the family shop; no one declares complete reconciliation in a single day. The expansion of these storylines keeps the memorial from being merely an intellectual dispute between Sarita and Ruhani.

Dvaraka's Boat and Incomplete Ancestor Rites: The Deliberate Separation of Temporal Layers

In an intervening scene at ancient Dvaraka's landing, a boatman refuses permission to scratch his dead brother's name onto his boat for a royal victory song. His wife does not want a public nameplate that day. Balarama recognises the ownership of the boat; Krishna insists that the human relationship embodied in a name remains independent of royal ornament. The commercial terms of Shailaj's modern company and the ancient dynasty's glory are not the same thing, but the narrative editing lets us read in parallel two different pressures to sever remembrance of the dead from the decisions of living families.

Ramsakhi recovers a brass plaque with incomplete lettering from underfoot and places it in a secure box without assigning an identity to it. Shailaj wishes to attach it to the museum proposal; Padma records the place, time, and witnesses of its discovery. The metal is neither final proof of any dead person's name nor a key granting the company new ownership. Had the story immediately transformed the object into the solution of a historical mystery, the central conflict over the making of public memory would have diminished. Delay keeps its meaning open.

Tendering, Consent, and Acknowledged Dissent: The Development of the Plot

Tara divides the problem into four decisions: space for remembrance, the stone contract, repairs, and the list of names. Ruhani and Sarita recognise the incompleteness of each other's positions. Their joint proposal provides for families to choose whether names are included, a safe place to light an unnamed lamp, the actual cost of public copies, and separate permission for private photographs and letters. Earlier wage and compensation claims are not ended by this memorial. Shailaj can bid for construction in a competitive tender, but receives no monopoly over the list of names.

The municipal officer accepts a temporary suspension of construction and an open tender; two technical options await examination. Some people are

disappointed by the delay. Shailaj's potential profit is reduced, but the narrative does not automatically declare her company criminal. Sarita can say “not yet” to using her daughter Naira's name while another woman says “yes” to her husband's. The presumed necessity of producing the same public statement from identical grief breaks down. These untimely and unequal desires give this chapter a more convincing polyphony than many preceding ones.

The Empty Glass and the Next Struggle over Leadership

Returning to the shelter at night, Ruhani reads two conflicting letters: old volunteers ask her to leave office, while younger members demand an end to control of both public ledgers and private information by one signature. The memorial dispute thus opens another narrative route into institutional leadership. Sarita goes home without removing Naira's empty glass or placing it on a public nameplate; she watches it while heating water on the stove. The algae-stained hand, Farzana's boxes, and Urmila's sister's body move within her reflections on memory. This emotionally dense scene returns the committee's public dispute to the ordinary recurrence of private grief.

The chapter's weakness is that virtually every commercial claim is immediately analysed in explicit language. Yet the genuine bitterness between Sarita and Ruhani, together with the uncertainty of the construction schedule, prevents a simplistic ending of moral triumph. The memorial contract has not been awarded; cleaning and repair of the landing continue; the unanswered question of leadership becomes the cause of the next chapter. This is not an obligatory item on an agenda, but the narrative consequence of consent breaking down within the shelter.

Chapter 184 — Ruhani's Election

The Broken Corner of the Ballot Box: A Visual Prelude to Leadership

Ruhani notices the broken corner of a yellow ballot box in Videhapur in 2041. She turns it upside down to examine the bamboo shavings and half-driven nail within. Instead of a sacred vessel of election, the reader sees a communal object in need of repair. The memorial dispute has brought allegations of favouritism against Ruhani, but the younger activists' demand is not simply her dismissal: they want the keys to the public ledger and confidential files removed from the control of a single person. The broken box in the opening awaits collective repair by the elected group in the ending, establishing a material circle between beginning and conclusion.

In the dispute over who may vote, Hiravati works by day, Janki lives in a moving household, and Ruhani herself is not a permanent resident. The rules say “regular public contributor,” without defining a period. Padma produces the six-month attendance register; Ruhani refuses sole authority to add or exclude voters. The temporal meaning of “shelter member” thus opens out: work beyond a residential bed, disaster shifts, and public service also build an institution. Before a vote is counted, the election story examines the discursive structure of the franchise.

Candidates' Voices, Conditions Attached to Donations, and Time for Appeal

Jharna is an independent candidate on the strength of two years of flood-relief shifts; she rejects being called “Ruhani's girl.” Mahendra points to his real contribution during earlier relief-vehicle operations but wants broad emergency signing powers for the chairperson so agreements with donors can be concluded quickly. Jharna questions the conflation of power to authorise emergency treatment with permanent use of names and documents. The two characters desire different things; turning Mahendra into a merely villainous rival would erase his genuine relief work and the fears of his supporters.

Mahendra's supporters tie a company's donation pledge to his victory, although the text specifies “continuity of executive leadership,” not any particular name. Mahendra admits his misreading of it, and the letter goes into a public proposal box separate from the ballot box. When two ballots prove ambiguous, the reasons are read publicly and the votes counted twice. Jharna wins by a small but clear margin. A seven-day review process is established for Mahendra's written objection; the result takes effect today, but the possibility of a recount is not wholly closed. This incomplete control preserves genuine democratic tension in narrative terms.

Ruchi and Chhabili's Knot, and Shanti's Wedding Canopy: Labour Beyond the Election

Ruchi Dharikar and Chhabili bring a woven bamboo safety-warning mat. Ruchi's family weaving, Chhabili's altered knot, and the wish to supply a municipal service are contained in the same handmade object. Jharna proposes separate arrangements for individual credit, raw material, hourly wages, testing, and reprinting. One of Chhabili's knots sits crooked; Janki stresses the importance of testing a safety notice. A mother's testimony provides the practical basis for her daughter becoming a weaver, but the daughter's correction of her own mistake makes her an independent craftswoman within the narrative.

Shanti Bari refuses to provide a wedding crown and decorative canopy without pay on the pretext of a donation. She asks for half the cost in advance and the remainder on handover, offering a lighter, lower-rental canopy to a family with a small budget. The bride herself chooses the lighter decoration and pays the first advance from her savings. At the close, the raw-material advance for Ruchi's initial consignment of thirty safety signs and a real advance for Shanti's canopy are approved or received; safety testing of Chhabili's new knot remains outstanding. These parallel event sequences join the political time of the election to the time of craftspeople's wages.

Ancient Guards at the Landing and the Transfer of Keys: Different Rhythms of Time

Amid the modern vote count, ancient Dvaraka supplies a claim by Yadava youths to first rights over guarding the landing. Samba insists on the ruling lineage's wishes, while an elderly boatman lists the tides, fishing boats, and night routes needed by the sick. Krishna reminds them of the actual labour of ropes pulled by force. The proposal will not take effect without a public hearing; Samba remains displeased. The ancient meeting has no direct causal relationship to the modern election, but the reader can see a structural tension across periods when the authority of office attempts to take possession of public time.

After winning, Jharna first asks for three keys: the public register, the materials store, and the private health room. She returns the third to the officer responsible for confidential maintenance; the first two are handed over with receipts. Ruhani experiences relief and emptiness together. This bodily contradiction prevents the founder's relinquishment of office from becoming a flat moral victory: throughout many nights of disaster those keys had become an extension of Ruhani's body. By dividing custody of the keys, Jharna turns distinctions between institutional powers into tangible action.

The Final Outcome, the Power of the Analysis, and Remaining Doubts

Ruhani voluntarily declines to stand for chairperson, but says she will remain available to account for old agreements. Jharna is elected; Mahendra takes his acknowledgment of objection; the separate election of a public auditor remains for the future. Tara proposes a three-month review cycle, and Champa distinguishes the person checking an account from the person required to render it. A new envelope containing Shailaj's revised donation terms arrives at night and is not accepted immediately. A notice reading “Leadership has changed; dues, appeals, and the limits of

consent have not vanished" expresses both continuity of work and the limits of power.

The chapter's narrative distinction is to link uncertainty in vote counting, the history of nominations, frustrated defeat, and Ruhani's emptiness to independent events in craft livelihoods. Its limitation is the exceptionally ordered pace of written solutions for each issue, which sometimes makes an actual election look less disorderly than it is. Nevertheless, the two ambiguous ballots, Mahendra's dissent, the untested knot, and the unopened donation letter keep the story's future genuinely open. The final algae-covered steps tell us that the founder's departure from office has not completed either the ecological or the social repair of the landing.

ASHRAMAVASIKA PARVA / UTTARA KANDA: COMPLETE COMPARATIVE NARRATOLOGICAL ASSESSMENT OF CHAPTERS 169–180

The Parva's Creative Direction: From the Right to Stay to the Right to Leave

The first eight chapters of Ashramavasika Parva establish separate narrative strands: the decisions of the ageing Dhritarashtra, Gandhari, and Kunti; Ishaan's public study room; Maithili's choice of residence; medicine for Champa's mother; Kabir's unsent letter; and Sarita's everyday time after bereavement. The final four chapters extend these strands through Savitri's visit to the fair, Vidura's departure, Suvasa's refusal to forgive, and the lives of Hiravati and Sarayu beyond the shelter. Across these twelve chapters, "going to the forest" is not merely a repeated condition of leaving the world behind. It is a dramatic combination of a person's capacity to choose a place, the survival of rights after change, and the limited obligations that relationships carry. (Chapters 169–180)

At the parva's close Ruhani writes on a board outside the shelter that the voices of people entering, remaining outside, and returning again must be heard separately. Reaching this conclusion involves one sequence of objects in the ancient hermitage—the staff, drainage channel, cracked measure, and Vidura's sandals—and another in modern life: a house key, a prescription, a mat, and a lamp bought at the fair. They are not repetitions of a single conceptual term; they are local centres of different characters' labour, fatigue, futures, and memories. (Chapters 169–180)

Narrative Time: Recurrent Mornings and Incomplete Events

The two-day shortage caused by the hermitage grain measure is not remedied by a prayer on a single morning; Suvasa insists on inspection

again the following day. Within the care of modern families, the duration of medicine, Champa's hours of paid work, the daily return of Sarita's school key, and Sarayu's decision about a bed for two nights establish several small intervals. Their recurrence breaks the linear motion of "an event occurred and a solution was found." In Chapter 177, particularly, the choice to return from the fair arises midway through the visit; in Chapter 179, not forgiving becomes a legitimate answer before any prescribed deadline; in Chapter 180, the right to return remains even after the shelter has been left.

Analepsis, moreover, does not serve as a heap of grand historical background. Savitri's memory of an earlier fair gives new meaning to the present five-rupee lamp; Maithili's memory of a shared rainy day does not force her to reject a separate home in the present; Kabir's memories of Naira become an imaginary letter that receives no answer; Sarita's mornings do not seek to erase the condition of mourning. Third-person narration in the ancient scenes and close observation in the modern period combine to resist the idea that a relationship must have one inevitable outcome. (Chapters 173–177)

Polyphony: Independent Narrative Paths Outside the Helping Institution

The contributions of Rama, Padma, Champa, Savitri, Phulmati, the elderly tenant, Gauri, Reva, Janki, Hiravati, Chandra, and Aruna are not confined to confirming the leading characters' arguments. The elderly tenant refuses to surrender her home despite the leaking roof. The modern committee permits Phulmati's error concerning a share in the net to be corrected in her own words. Gauri builds an alliance without claiming to define the personal journeys of its members. Hiravati secures a weekly place of work while keeping open the investigation into her right to a permanent home. Such distinct outcomes provide a living possibility of polyphony. (Chapters 177–180)

The excessively explicit language of organisational theory nevertheless constitutes a limitation. Many characters explain the distinctions among "separate items," "limited consent," and "receipt" with nearly identical expertise at the same time. More scenes could have accommodated stubborn silence, misunderstanding rooted in interests, and uncomfortable reactions specific to a character. Ancient Suvasa's clear refusal and the forthcoming divergence between modern Sarita and Ruhani are especially effective instances in which this stylistic uniformity breaks.

Intertexts Across Two Times: The Actual Use of Mythic Remains

Dhritarashtra's ancient hermitage is not merely a classical platform for the ideas of a modern committee. The cracked grain measure, the forest woman's water, Aruna's roof, and Vidura's journey north occur with their own material objects, local pressures, and unfinished consequences. Life in modern Videhapur belongs to a separate history and a different institutional temporality from the outset. Narrative editing produces recurring questions between the two worlds—whose voice is heard, at whose expense help is supplied, and whose memory is treated as decisive. But it does not claim that one character has literally been reborn as another or that an event in one period constitutes evidence for an event in the other. (Chapters 177–180)

Vidura's refusal to throw his ring into the river is an act of particular creative restraint. The past does not end in a theatrical gesture: its unfinished responsibilities remain in his bag. The old lock from the modern school is likewise not discarded but placed with objects of historical interest. The two objects have different meanings. One man carries a memory of his ministerial position; a community keeps a reminder of an earlier monopoly. Yet their juxtaposition leads the reader to consider the imperfect process of changing an old order.

The Narrative Form of the Archive: Rejecting Total Resolution

Against the modern background of Ashramavasika Parva, "consent received" does not mean "payment completed"; "two nights at the shelter" does not mean "permanent rehabilitation"; "an apology" does not mean "a claim extinguished." The central realist technique of these chapters consists in giving different documents distinct narrative durations. Sarita, Rama, and Padma correct records, but paper never fully substitutes for direct experience. Savitri's knee, Chandra's ankle bells, and Hiravati's mat remain residual relations that cannot be contained upon the page. (Chapters 177–180)

The parva's real achievements are no smaller on that account: separate mechanisms for hearings and appeals, an older person's independent decisions, a public route for correcting records, Gauri's alliance with limited aims, different forms of service inside and outside the shelter, and room to refuse personal forgiveness. The fact that many payments and investigations remain pending is not a defect of incompleteness in the story; it is the temporal extension of life continuing beyond an apparently orderly decision. The critical conclusion is this: Ashramavasika Parva is not a story of "leaving everything and finding peace," but of different times for leaving, remaining, receiving help, and refusing. (Chapters 169–180)

MAUSALA PARVA / UTTARA KANDA: FIRST COMPARATIVE NARRATOLOGICAL ASSESSMENT OF CHAPTERS 181–184

From the Colours of a Festival to an Institutional Ballot Box

The opening four chapters of Mausala Parva move from the many-sided events of a festival to an election within the shelter. Chapter 181 presents the victory celebration's stage, the donor's brass wheel, and the craft dispute concerning a metal coupling; Chapter 182 brings Deepak's trembling body and medical needs together with Suman's design; Chapter 183 turns to the memorial contract and the bitterness between Sarita and Ruhani; Chapter 184 follows the voters' register, Jharna's victory, and the actual transfer of keys. The sequence does not simply chart the progressive success of institutional reform. It gives narrative shape to the emergence of new power relations within the spectacle of celebration. (Chapters 181–184)

The four short sequences in ancient Dvaraka have their own independent progression: the obstruction of the landing during displays of victory, the pressure exerted by intoxicated young men, the royal appropriation of a dead boatman's name for commemoration, and younger Yadavas' demands for control over guarding the landing. Krishna's and Balarama's decisions remove particular local obstacles each day, but Samba's dissatisfaction and the pride of young members of the ruling house survive. This residual discontent is not a certain signpost to the coming catastrophe; it is an unresolved alteration in the exercise of power within these chapters. (Chapters 181–184)

Cuts between Narrative Strands and the Characters' Independent Times

Sumitra's load test takes the story away from the glittering stage to dangerous timber. The duration of Deepak's treatment does not follow the pace of slogans or police investigation; Rakesh's wages for three nights are a separate matter. Suman's limited permission for forty boards establishes a time frame for trade; Naira's remembrance remains within Sarita's private, uncertain duration. Two ambiguous ballots open a seven-day review even as Jharna begins work. Because these durations are unequal, the four chapters cannot be reduced to a single explanatory slogan. (Chapters 181–184)

Particular attention must be paid to the independent social work of every supporting character: Rukhsana's cooking, Chandra's singing, Sumitra's metal coupling, Nazir's tests, Suman's drawing, Ramsakhi's cleaning of algae, Farzana's bangles, Kamala's food, Ruchi and Chhabili's warning signs, and Shanti's wedding canopy. None of these strands is merely a

symbol dependent on the protagonist. Most describe concrete stages of actual advances, unpaid balances, raw materials, customer choices, or safety tests. (Chapters 181–184)

The Recurrence of Objects and Narrative Rhythm

The brass wheel, the cup, the incomplete plaque, and the ballot box share a metallic attraction as a sequence of objects, yet form distinct meanings. The first wheel embodies the glitter of sponsorship; the next cup opens a scene of the endangered body; the incomplete brass plaque carries an uncertain history; and the ballot box's damaged corner visualises a democratic institution in need of repair. This is not mechanical symbolism. Each object's practical use, the hand that touches it, and the event following it determine its narrative meaning. (Chapters 181–184)

Sarita's empty glass and Ruhani's bunch of keys are countervailing private objects within this metallic series. The glass resists the conversion of grief into a public nameplate; the keys make departure from office a mingled sensation of years of service and control. After the public bitterness of Chapter 183, the small touch between Sarita and Ruhani in Chapter 184 is not a complete reconciliation announced with laughter. When the right to run an institution passes from one body to another's hands, the emotions of the relationship do not become simple by decree.

An Interim Assessment and the Test Posed by the Six Remaining Chapters

The completed events of Chapters 181–184 should be kept separate: part of the stage is closed following safety tests; Sumitra's future share in production is written down; Deepak accepts further treatment; Suman enters a limited printing agreement; the monopolistic memorial contract is stopped pending competitive review; and Jharna is elected chairperson by a narrow but clear margin. Matters unfinished include the outcome of Deepak's treatment, full wages owed by the contractor, construction of the memorial, Mahendra's objection about ambiguous ballots, testing Chhabili's knot, and Shailaj's revised donation terms. Ignoring this difference would turn criticism into a congratulatory summary. (Chapters 181–184)

A stylistic problem remains: character dialogue repeatedly possesses a remarkably complete command of procedural distinctions, so that certain scenes resemble policy documents more than lived narration. Yet the trembling of Deepak's body, the bitterness between Sarita and Ruhani, Mahendra's refusal to acquiesce, and Ruhani's emptiness creatively disrupt this excessive orderliness. This is only an interim judgement on Chapters

181–184. An overall conclusion on Mausala Parva must await reading the subsequent original chapters. (Chapters 181–184)

Chapter 185 — Conditions of the Donation

Opening the Envelopes: Rights in the Language of Generosity

At dawn in 2041, the new chairperson, Jharna, sets two envelopes aside. Shailaj's company, though renouncing perpetual monopoly over a name, still claims the rights of a principal promotional partner. Devavrat's letter attaches the vague phrase “protection from unnecessary disputes” to funding for medical care and the kitchen. Neither gift is, by itself, innocent or evidence of crime; each is a narrative proposal shaped by its donor's interests. Jharna first provides water for the elderly. This ordinary need anchors narrative time amid the unusual tension of the papers.

Rama's statement—that she has no authority either to find Devavrat guilty or to declare him innocent because he donated—centres the chapter's unresolved condition. Dispatch and receipt registers disagree over an earlier medicine consignment; Mahesh's death and alleged threats remain under examination elsewhere. Instead of collapsing these different timelines into a sensational disclosure, the story preserves distinct investigations. Their delay is not simply a device of suspense but the social duration of work proceeding simultaneously.

Palm Sap, a Cooking Pot, and a Deposit Slip: Counter-Narratives of Giving

Suraj Chaudhary's worn palms, a vessel bearing dried sap, and an empty bottle open the assembly to life outside it. His father's inherited expertise and the son's wish for safer climbing, basic training, clean non-intoxicating drink, and producer ownership stand in tension. A mark licensed for the first ten batches differs from a lifelong right to reproduce it. Nandu finally accepts separate payment for training labour: the inherited skill is not destroyed, but the physical price of practising it becomes visible.

Amina's blanket-wrapped cooking pot and two police receipts for meals offer the sharpest small counter-story. Paying for meals already eaten is not charity. Behind that sentence are actual cash payment, a written order, and the completed correction of “assistance meals” to “purchased meals.” Arun Barnwal's tax deposit, an outstanding amount open to appeal, and withheld workers' wages belong to different timelines. One worker receives money; another is still owed. These uneven minor achievements establish society's actual pace amid the speed of public ideals.

A Sea-Scene in Two Times and the Material Form of Giving

In ancient Dvaraka a clan head offers a pot of grain for repairs to a wooden bridge, while demanding first passage for his own boat. The ageing boatman's labour and the common right of passage conflict with this condition. Krishna refers the privilege for a separate hearing; the grain feeds workers, only one section of bridge is repaired, and Samba still feels insulted. This is not historical proof of modern banking rules, but a comparable tension between donation and control of access, situated in an independent narrative time.

The grain pot, dried-sap vessel, empty cooking pot, deposit slip and empty bottle at night do not repeat one metaphor. They signify, respectively, workers' food, ancestral skill, the worth of sales, a legitimate due and the precariousness of future production. The narrator connects the contemporary meeting with the ancient landing without claiming the earlier day caused the modern decision. This distinction makes the epic intertext a rewriting rather than an imposition.

Delayed Voting, Dissent and Independent Leadership

The seven stated conditions include an independent account, privacy, transparent supplies, no waiver of appeals in exchange for services, autonomy of old investigations, and procedures for suspension and recovery in cases of error. A woman asking about her child's medicine briefly turns those rules into urgent human concerns. A specified limited portion of the fund is approved for immediate needs; the rest is withheld pending checks. Mahendra's dissent is entered into the record, and Jharna refuses to extend her casting authority beyond the rules. The first trial after a change in leadership is a self-binding decision, not a command.

Ruhani's question about expenditure on oil is decisive: the moral independence of leadership cannot overlook the ordinary budgets of stove and lamp. Devavrat's discontent does not disappear. Signing revised terms signifies acceptance of those terms, not final resolution of every allegation. An unsigned photocopy emerging from Tara's office at the end anticipates the next chapter. Rather than provide closure, the story turns toward the possibility of error on the critical side itself.

Critical Conclusion: Polyphony's Strength and the Density of Speech

Jharna, Devavrat, Mahendra, Suraj, Nandu, Amina and Arun are not interchangeable voices chanting unity: each inhabits distinct financial risks, memories and temporal horizons. Almost all, however, express objections in exceptionally organised rights-based language. The density of committee proposals sometimes contracts the reader's interpretative

space. Amina's empty pot, Nandu beneath the palm and Ruhani's question about oil resist that didactic pressure and preserve tangible life.

Chapter 186 — Tara's Error

The Reversed Claim "Consent Obtained": A Self-Critical Character

The chapter opens with the smell of decayed paper in a cupboard and the red annotation "consent obtained." Tara did not forge the signature found on the photocopy, but had relied upon the office notation in allowing a decision to proceed. The moral distinction between these responsibilities is the point. The actual attendance register concerned a meeting on safely clearing the mouth of a watercourse; consent to permanent use entered the papers later. Aditi's technical permission for a "site inspection" was not the "permanent use" written on the truncated sheet. The narration identifies what the error means without yet identifying its author.

Tara publicly admits her mistake in using the document. She does not dismiss Mahendra's question—whether she herself wrote the falsehood—but distinguishes the known from the unknown. The route to Mahendra's aunt's house turns the misleading phrase into a risk to human life. Jharna suspends new permanent acquisition based on the disputed paper but permits safe temporary passage to continue. Immediate restraint and the comprehensive investigation remain separate narrative events.

The Father's Bamboo Work and the Daughter's Knot: Division of Credit Within the Family

In three bamboo prototypes attributed to Shyam Mallik, the labour of Tara's new knot has been absorbed under her father's name. Family trust had effaced her separate wages. Tara distinguishes the bamboo's material price from the labour of the knot; Shyam acknowledges that the customer's earlier advance was spent on household expenses. This admission alone cannot establish the amount of old wages. Joint credit appears on the new prototype, while past dues await reconciliation of bank accounts.

Tara uses tweezers to remove a thorn from Shyam's finger. The father and daughter meet outside the office, without a certificate of praise. Shyam refuses to reduce her character to one error but does not offer instant forgiveness. Their relationship follows a different duration from the administrative correction. "Knot" signifies an actual craft operation and recalls an unresolved account, but the symbolism remains bound to measurable work rather than turning into an abstract sermon.

Bangles, Bags of Thread and Commercial Independence

Human irregularity in Rekha Sahu Laheri's lac bangles may count as a technical flaw in the market, but ownership of the original pattern and the privacy of a customer's measurements are distinct questions. Nasim receives limited permission for a machine test of forty bangles, with losses from damaged material shared. Four emerge correctly; the fifth cracks. The video is kept for joint examination, not advertising. A new advance is paid, but the older dispute over copied designs remains unsettled.

Saqib Abdal's blue bag for public money and red bag for personal funds are a striking visual distinction. The purchase of rope is verified; one transport charge remains under scrutiny. Choosing to cut household expenditure rather than draw on public money exposes the familial price of integrity. His daughter's question about schoolbooks gives material form to the abstract term "transparency." The narrator presents Saqib neither as a flawless saint nor as wholly innocent, but includes his mistake and its cost.

Correction of a Public Error and the Unheard Jhingri

Tara withdraws the false annotation. The timetable allows seven days for objections, fifteen to trace the original register and thirty for an independent hearing. Private signatures are not placed on the public board, which displays only the substance of the dispute, differences of documentary basis and objection deadline. Dated copies go to offices, panchayat and affected groups; still, the person responsible for the original signature is unknown. Correction does not invent a convenient new past: it undertakes to preserve evidence of the earlier error.

Jhingri's two days of withheld wages and her lack of an opportunity to object extend the inquiry significantly. Her petition is registered afresh, with inspection ordered for one uncontested day's attendance; she has not been paid. Rukhsana's letter opens the communal-kitchen issue at the close. Five independent labour narratives emerge in succession from an apparent document error, without becoming remedies for that error alone. The wet flag at the watercourse and the lantern's thin wick figure correction as ceaseless effort with scarce resources, not a glorious victory.

A Critical Limitation of the Narrative Craft

In a single day numerous characters identify due process and propose effective remedies. Their collective reasoning carries ethical strength, but sophisticated institutional thought sounds too uniformly arranged in individual voices. The cracked fifth bangle, outstanding transport verification, Mahendra's doubt and Shyam's unbalanced accounts nonetheless prevent hasty resolution. Credibility survives in continuously outstanding questions rather than an announced verdict.

Chapter 187 — The Kitchen's Deficit

Forty Names, Twenty-Seven Plates: Quantitative Conflict in Narrative

At four in the morning an ember survives in the ashes. Forty names stand above an approval for twenty-seven plates, joining numerical inequality to bodily time. The volunteer who entered thirteen additional names overnight testifies to hunger, but writing names does not create grain, fuel or labour. “Accounts before fire,” Rukhsana insists, imposing an essential pause on narrative speed. A rat-gnawed sack, spoiled lentils and split palms translate the contrivance of accounting into the physical experience of work.

Rukhsana adds a fifth category to Padma's four columns: “loss from spoiled goods.” It separates ordinary food wastage, deliberately defective supplies and compensation forced onto the cook. The narrator does not simply count impartially; the holes made by rats, damaged aubergines and transport pressures give visible causes for the numerical deficits. The list is no final truth, but a narrative object subject to reconstruction.

Raghu's Roasting Shop, Chandrika's Fried Cakes and Women's Voluntary Work

Raghu Sahu's grain-roasting business is not automatically favoured by relief operations. His customers declined when the relief camp began roasting its own grain. A definite two-day order does not restore the old market. Chandrika Rai Halwai's receipt for seventy fried cakes receives partial payment later; a balance remains outstanding. A small advance for a new order does not erase this insecure history. The two episodes show that social assistance can indirectly diminish another person's livelihood.

Gurmeet Kaur distinguishes voluntary religious service from wages due for sustained, assigned work. At the fish and makhana labour fair the costs of Phulmati's boat, fuel and net, and Dhaniya's sorting, become clear. Spoiled leaves among Salman's vegetables demonstrate that affection between siblings does not extinguish commercial responsibility. The occupational voices coexist without losing their individual economic conditions. Polyphony means more than identifying castes or faiths; it requires distinct payment arrangements and forms of disagreement.

The Mother's Memory and the Narrative Time of Rest

Rukhsana recalls her mother showing her how to make use of bruised aubergines; her mother did not order women to labour for eternity. This analepsis imposes a temporal limit upon the everyday maxim “Nothing is

wasted in poverty." Rukhsana's demand for a complete and scheduled interval of rest is the chapter's internal climax: for once the kitchen's story withdraws the condition of the cook's endless availability.

After the new shift register comes into force, Rukhsana sits at home for half an hour without opening an account, watches her daughter play marbles and makes a thin flatbread for herself. Her meal is neither one of twenty-seven nor one of forty. Her late mother's handkerchief and smoke from the distant shelter become not final proof of successful policy but sensuous experiences of time belonging to oneself. The ending moves outside the document into a silent interval of life.

Limited Provision for Meals and a Parallel in Two Times

Rice is obtained for seven more plates, but vegetables and fuel are not immediately available. Meals for people with medical priority and ordinary relief are timed separately. Food for those still waiting is confirmed at another centre. Jharna suspends spending on promotional banners, introduces a one-month trial rate and orders weekly review. Only the provision of that day's food is accomplished; neither permanent funding nor Rukhsana's full recovery of health is established.

An elderly cook at an ancient Dvaraka public feast demands to know why her work has disappeared from the record. Krishna orders separate accounts for food remaining, spoiled and used, as well as her wages and rest. The royal family's neglect does not thereby end. This is not the former life of Rukhsana. By placing grain, fire and utensils in different social times, the narrative shows how the celebration of renown can drown out a worker's voice.

Readerly Distance and Critical Assessment

Chandrika's two-line sign, "Relief is free / Labour is not," is intellectually effective. Yet repeated statements that function as maxims of policy may reduce the reader's unmediated experience. Rukhsana's swollen wrist, half-burnt firewood, split aubergine and playing daughter give the narrative more independence. Its achievement is to measure the success of relief not merely in plates served but in the invisible time spent making them possible.

Chapter 188 — The Market for Tools

Three Measurements in Iron and a Fourth, Sealed Chest

A ring, a hook and a ploughshare on the morning anvil belong to three lawful orders; the fourth object, an unnamed sealed chest, remains indeterminate. Earlier publicity merged this chest of unknown origin with

Harinarayan's ordinary tools in a single crime narrative, causing customers to disappear. Ajit's fear of rent and his father's decision to show work-specific orders mark the actual duration of family livelihood, not merely the mechanics of a mystery. The narrative sends the chest for separate, secure investigation rather than opening it for sensation.

Police inspection finds the regular orders compatible with legitimate work, without finally establishing the source of an unnamed plate or the older seized chest. Nandlal cannot cover the whole loss from his fear-driven cancellation, but pays an actual advance for a ploughshare. Ajit's hope remains a question: will all customers return? Three sales, one advance and two incomplete orders limit the record of success to an uneven reality.

The Potter's Leaking Vessel and the Trainee Farrier's Limits

Kamlesh Dabgar displays a customer's leaking pot while refusing to collect the whole fee for unfinished drainage repairs. The unfinished repair is more than evidence; it becomes a dramatic counterexample of a craftsperson's honesty. A two-month temporary rental agreement is reached, with the additional deposit to be paid in instalments; previous flood damage is not compensated. The shop can reopen tomorrow, yet future rent remains disputable. The narrator declines to call this permanent resettlement.

Salim the farrier brings two boxes: horseshoeing tools and equipment for modern vehicle training. Familiarity with older tools does not establish competence in inspecting new braking systems. He accepts only limited axle repair, retaining the need for a trained inspector's certificate; the earlier training allowance has not been credited. His father's incomplete acceptance and the income lost during training prevent a contrived victory for either the old or the new occupation. Generational tension appears in prices, competence and records rather than spectacular anger.

The Market's Many Voices: Photographs, Authorities and Customers

A young man's attempt to designate the hook a criminal object on the strength of a cropped photograph makes public suspicion visible. Jharna asks for verified names and sources. Shabnam, Rama, Rekha and Farzana expose the difference between genuine safety rules and a proposed "permitted trading" board whose authorisation would require private advertising fees. Customers continue to disagree. Aditi's warning—that inspecting some tools is not proof that the entire boat route is safe—wins little applause, but the boatmen ask for a written copy. Uneven public response prevents a spectacle of unanimous victory.

Hira's knot, Phulmati's net, Lalit's timber, Salim's wheel and Harinarayan's ring reveal a division of labour across the community. But if each person's caution is translated into an equally accomplished policy statement, distinctions among social registers are endangered. Ajit's faltering account book, Nandlal's fear and Salim's relation to his father rescue these lives from excessive rhetorical clarity.

The Small Scene of a Nail and an Ancient Metal Vessel

Ajit picks up a small nail and asks whether making it should cease because someone might misuse it. Harinarayan distinguishes the tool's intended purpose, the purchaser's actions and wrongful use. The question returns to the reader, while the narrator resists making it the final law nailed to the gate. Outstanding debt and an operating market demand attention at the same time.

A final isolated scene in ancient Dvaraka shows Balarama learning that no one can name the worker who carried a metal vessel marked with the royal insignia. It prepares the emotional setting of his coming withdrawal; it neither explains the anonymous modern chest nor proves a theory. The narrative's strength is not in turning old metal into a political emblem, but in rendering the unnamed worker's absence as an absence within the story itself.

Chapter 189 — Balarama's Withdrawal

The Ancient World as the Principal Focal Centre, and the Responsibility of Silence

The first nine textual units of the chapter remain within ancient Dvaraka. The upturned feast platter bears its owner's emblem, but not the name of the worker who washed or carried it. Kailash's son is recorded as having worked two days rather than three; his complaint was stifled by invoking “Balarama's name.” The story confronts a powerful man with the misuse of his name while he was absent. Responsibility is distributed: Balarama did not commit every injustice, but he bears part of the silence created under his authority.

A young man's accusation—that Balarama taught strength but now restrains it—opens an analepsis. He remembers being taught to strike; whether a victorious child was also taught to lift the defeated one is left unanswered. Balarama takes his hand away from the handle of his mace. This is not a formal abdication but a silent decision to restrain the possibility of rage. In comparing accounts with Krishna, the two do not immediately declare a decisive case of corruption; they separately mark discrepancies between grain left and expenditure recorded.

Leaving the Royal Seat Versus Evading a Citizen's Question

Festival waste has blocked the water route to a young woman's home behind the landing. Rather than simply order water brought to her, Balarama asks which path she herself uses. Guards are removed from the footpath; the remaining cleaning is scheduled. An elderly boatman's voice and young men's accusation that he is an “outsider” strike contrasting notes in the royal assembly. Balarama sits on a lower step and calls his silence a responsibility. This bodily change of position conveys more than the language of office.

Finally Balarama chooses an independent path of practice, distancing himself from everyday royal festivities, without relinquishing responsibility for a written examination of verified dues. Krishna does not prevent his departure. This voluntary withdrawal is not a replica of renunciation in the novel's Ashramavasika Parva: here an adult wielder of power wants to diminish the shadow of his own presence. The story retains its question: will his distance secure justice, or create a fresh vacancy? The next chapter will test the consequences.

Milk, Hammer and Drum in the Present: Three Independent Livelihoods

In the modern strand, Bhola Yadav actually receives in his bank account the final payment for four days' milk supply, though the omission of a second child's name from the milk-assistance list remains disputed. Because he has a possible financial interest, he does not vote on eligibility, but retains the right to report what he has witnessed. The two social positions of a citizen—benefiting trader and community witness—are sustained within the dialogue.

Inspection finds no basis for the accusation against Nazir Sikligar's ordinary tools, but the loss of four months' customers is not undone. Harinarayan receives a real order to repair a broken latch while inquiry into an anonymous metal consignment continues separately. Karun Damai asks for distinct fees for instrument repair and the following day's performance; the organiser agrees to separate advance and balance. Repair costs for a loose stage plank are not deducted from the artist's honorarium. These are not three claims settled by one courtlike ruling, but three kinds of labour unfolding in different times.

Rhythm, Listening and the Structure of Private Consent

The last soft beat of Karun's newly tightened drum is heard after Rukhsana's appointed working hours have ended. She does not rush back to offer help; her quiet restraint extends the earlier chapter's right to rest. Ruhani brings a proposal for digital recording as a witness, but does not

supply a final signature. Karun separates permission to record private rehearsal from consent for public broadcast. A musical sound is therefore more than ornament: it becomes narrative space for an artist's rights over his own sound.

A limitation is that the three contemporary occupational episodes risk blending into one register of meticulously correct policy dialogue. Yet the daughter questioning the milk list, Nazir's dwindling clientele, a little girl's wish to dance, and Balarama's hand restraining anger introduce distinct human pauses. The narration evokes a metaphorical resemblance between his ancient choice and modern lives, never a literal causal connection.

Chapter 190 — Krishna's End

Crisis by the Ancient Sea and Incomplete Testimony

The chapter opens with a bloodstained rope in ancient Dvaraka and calls for missing people. Amid intoxication, old humiliations and mutual assaults, the identity of the youth who first raised a weapon is uncertain. A wounded boatwoman admits that she did not see the whole beginning, and Krishna has that incomplete testimony recorded as such. It would be easy to describe the dynasty's destruction as an eternal curse in one grand image. Instead the story gives narrative room to the wounded boatwoman, Kutiladevi's missing grandson and a terrified child.

Hard reed stems become weapons, called by onlookers the destined pestles; each blow, however, is delivered by a human hand. The conjunction of mythical naming and human agency is the chapter's decisive intertextual device. Krishna first orders aid to the injured without clearing up the disputed identity of the aggressors. “Great destruction” consequently becomes not one unbroken heroic spectacle but a crisis of separate homes and incomplete lists.

The Hunter Jara's Arrow: Distinctions Among Knowledge, Sight and Consequence

In the forest, Jara mistakes a gleaming shape in the grass for a deer's ear and releases an arrow without seeing the whole body. The arrow strikes Krishna's foot. The hunter's claim that he meant no killing does not alter the physical wound. Krishna forbids the forceful removal of the arrow and asks for water and cloth. The subsequent exchange holds together the hunter's fear, his expectation of retaliatory violence and the accounting of what happened. Artistically the scene is made less from sublime elevation of rasa than from fatigue, bleeding and an almost impossible last effort at care.

Krishna recalls the gambling hall, Sudama, Radhika, the war and grain ledgers in separate fragments. He does not gather every part of his life into one divine interpretation. The narrator states his death plainly. The sea does not stop; lists of those needing help and unfinished orders remain with the living. This philosophical breadth of closure is not detached from his situated body. On Jara's return, retaliation is stopped but death cannot be reversed; no final proclamation of forgiveness or punishment follows.

Resisting the Misuse of Krishna's Death in the Modern Strand

After the cut, the modern Videhapur narrative concerns Durga Danuwar's route through the forest to transport bamboo: it is neither Krishna's present-day rebirth nor a direct consequence of his death. A tender board announcing "route closed for safety" extends beyond the older seasonal restriction. Durga asks not for unlimited forest rights, but a restricted safe path and lawful quantities of bamboo. After genuine risk from a soil collapse is observed, heavy vehicles are barred, a timed pedestrian and bicycle route is opened, and the larger question of forest rights remains unsettled.

In Madhuri Dangi and Ananya's production of eighty bags of flattened rice and makhana, women's roasting, sorting and rates of labour are entered separately. The weight of two bags remains disputed; the first actual payment comes from the undisputed balance. Devan does not suddenly become an unqualified supporter at home: he refrains from tearing up the ledger and consents to the next trial. This small change does not solve the grief occasioned by Krishna's death. The contemporary narrative continues along an independent livelihood trajectory.

Naira's Death, Private Photographs and the Limits of Heroism

A local organiser wants to include Naira's photograph in a memorial portraying Krishna's divine vengeance. Sarita refuses plainly: Naira's death has its own circumstances and an investigation still incomplete; making it an act of mythical revenge would exploit grief. Kabir preserves his private unsent letter without opposing students' writing about Naira's public work at school. The narrator does not turn their two limited permissions into a counterfeit reconciliation.

The cut without a simplistic opposition poses a difficult question: may an epic ending lend meaning to modern grief, or would it claim ownership of that grief? Sarita's glass and the forest arrow are not equivalent symbols. One is a household object within a surviving relationship to a dead daughter; the other causes death within an ancient story. The narrator explicitly signals that the two events must remain distinct.

Assessment: The Intensity of Catastrophe and the Over-Explanation of Thought

The chapter's strongest elements are Krishna's final exhaustion, the unexpected wound inflicted by Jara and an elderly woman's request for one name. A tendency toward uniformly faultless moral caution in dialogue also threatens the death scene: Krishna retains an extraordinary steadiness of judgement which may diminish the possibility of human instability. Yet the scene does not evade bodily ending, partial testimony or time that will not return. In that refusal lies its real artistic achievement.

Chapter 191 — Not Everything Has Broken

The Third Round of Pond-Clearing and the Refusal of "Complete Success"

Gomati Beldar moves a bamboo stake a handspan backwards because the first position risks trapping soil underneath. This opening is not simply a statement of measurement but an immediate revision of action. At the third annual clearing of the pond and watercourses, the previous year's false attendance register is deliberately preserved: one man's time was entered twice, and the time worked by two women was suppressed. The narration rejects the easy linear history of tearing out the incorrect page and producing a spotless replacement.

Ramsakhi's thumb-marked attendance sheet conceals a waiver of payment and future compensation. Gomati institutes separate records of attendance, safety, rest and claims. Differences in pay for the same work based on a worker's face or identity are prohibited, while tool hire is accounted for separately. The contractor's objections are heard, but his convenience is not treated as equivalent to workers' rights.

Silt, Nets, Fields and the Incomplete Ecology of Honey

The eroding boundary of Suraj Gangota's field and the route needed for Phulmati's fish-fry net collide over disposal of silt. Gomati demands permission before earth is deposited; Ramani Bind points out an older water-level mark; Hira Mech distinguishes one safe landing from the end of flood damage as a whole. Water here is not merely a symbol. Its physical agency lies in soil density, opened drains, the extra expense of nets and shifting field boundaries.

Batohi Dhami's empty honey vessel signals uncertainty over the revival of an ancestral trade. The hives have moved, trees have fallen, and a new livelihood must still be developed within the restrictions of safe seasonal inspection. A bamboo box painted like Putul's book raises once again the

question of naming and ownership, but no honey has actually been collected. Instead of a declaration of optimism, the narrative supplies a training date and an empty vessel.

The Actual Time of Wages and One Digit in Ramsakhi's Account

The landing steps become usable, but a dangerous strip stays closed pending inspection. A rule requires wages to reach workers directly through accepted means, with witnessed cash payment available for those without bank accounts. One incorrect digit in Ramsakhi's account number delays her payment without stopping everyone else's. A correction is confirmed in the second half of the day. The narrative difference between an order to pay and money actually arriving becomes explicit.

On seeing the money, Ramsakhi does not raise a victory slogan. She calculates the needs of her stove, repairs to a basket and the cost of a notebook for her daughter. This minute calculation of a household future is a counter-time to public declarations of success. The blister on Gomati's hand and the shadows of old and new pages at night extend the same meaning: equality of labour entails a social rule and a body's uncomfortable continuity.

A Schoolgirl's Unfinished Picture and the Next Threat

A schoolgirl deliberately leaves one side of her picture of the clean landing unfinished because work has been halted there. This small, partial scene offers one of the novel's most successful explanations of its own form. The teacher's "Why haven't you finished the picture?" speaks to the reader's own impatience with an unfinished story. The child's answer is not a speech at a policy meeting, but an aesthetic boundary set by what she has seen.

The following morning a tender notice appears proposing an "authorised central owner" for digital copies. Tara first checks whether Gomati's system of three copies protects the community's share. The foreshadowing introduces the possibility of a new institutional claim against a locally successful labour register. Yet it is still only a tender proposal: ownership has not been granted to the company. Preserving that distinction is essential for the criticism to follow.

The Parva's Meaning: A Working Society After Disintegration

Following Krishna's death, this chapter is not a direct interpretation of the epic's next event. It tells the continuing story of grief, uprooted work and reconstruction in modern society. "Not everything has broken" is no unconditional reassurance. What survives includes the safe section of steps, a system of payment and the child's incomplete picture. What has not been

restored is the field in its entirety, the old worth of the fishing net or easy honey-gathering in the forest. Incompleteness here is not a failure of vision but a condition of assessment through scenes.

Chapter 192 — Fear of a New Owner

Against Exclusive Ownership in a World of Three Copies

At the archive door Tara does not tear down the disputed tender; she copies it line by line. The proposal for a central owner conflicts with the earlier system of three community-linked copies. Mahendra's argument for convenience has substance: ledgers became wet in the floods, and finding lost papers took time. Sanket does not deny the benefits of unified storage either. The dispute concerns the power to deny access and control corrections. Instead of convenient polemic against a villain, the story presents a fine conflict between administrative convenience and autonomy.

Suraj Gangota's copy records limited permission for drainage, with compensation still under consideration; the new draft merely states "consent obtained." Phulmati's ordinary repair of an old net and the additional loss caused by public works are merged into "net subsidy." These two material differences show how much violence a one-line category can do to narrative memory. The criticism nonetheless does not deliver a legal verdict: it asks whose voice and whose temporal limits a document can accommodate.

Sabina Mirshikar: A Person Beyond the Occupational Register

Sabina Mirshikar comes carrying a torn net and needle to ask the cost of a repair, not to join a movement to save archives. Someone proposes that she undertake prohibited hunting as if bound to her community's ancestral trade, but she chooses the modest lawful livelihood of mending nets. The company's proposed category of "eligible occupation" contains her old community name but no place for her new skill. Tara records her own words, while Sabina asks first for a fair price for one job and refuses permission to turn her life into an example. This resistance allows her to own her day rather than exist as an illustration of an argument.

Phulmati shows a third loose knot, which Sabina resews herself. The first instalment of payment arrives, not a permanent livelihood. A young family member returns with a suspicious, potentially lucrative offer; Sabina asks for clear details of price, location and legality, rejecting the uncertainty. Neither the character who declines risk nor the person bearing a family history is thereby made economically secure.

Three Colours of Thread: Circulating Accounts and the Memory of Correction

Sanket uses three threads to distinguish the issuing office, the community's received copy and the affected individual's private copy. These are not three legally identical “originals”; each has its own provenance and obligations. When they disagree, the proposal is to record a new statement of differences without erasing the old text. The story indirectly comments on its own writing: no single narrator is the ultimate owner of a person's or community's entire experience. Yet it does not reject the need for an authentic official record.

The actual expense of sign language, large print, audio copies and reading aloud is put on the agenda. An elderly woman wants first to understand where her recorded voice will go. The absent presence of Naira is remembered here, but never turned into an all-knowing moral command. Sarita asks that the unfinished edge of the surviving schoolgirl's pond picture remain independent, questioning the artificial pressure toward completeness.

The Status of the Vote and an Ending Without Inauguration

Jharna reads the revised draft: the lawful original is to remain in the issuing office, a received community copy in a separate secure box, and a private copy under the concerned individual's control. Outside technical assistance is acceptable; monopolising the power to deny access is not. In response to Mahendra's question about theft of the box, maintenance safeguards are added. The municipal tender, however, has not been cancelled, and a written objection still needs to be filed through the prescribed procedure.

A first test discovers a difference in the vowel mark of Ramsakhi's name. The amount is unaffected, but the name still needs correction. Seeing that Sabina's next net-mending appointment conflicts with her market day, Tara adjusts the time. The final sentence opens the way for “the journey by which a document reaches its owner.” Fear of a single owner has not been eliminated. Inequalities of travel and access become the next parva's major open question.

Overall Stylistic Assessment

The chapter contains intellectually dense dialogue about ownership of records. Yet if one reads only its administrative rules, the immediate scarcity of Sabina's life, Phulmati's net and Gomati's rough palms disappear. Several characters speak in such exquisitely polished procedural language that life's entanglements risk appearing as a printed manifesto. The knot resewn after a mistake, laughter over a plate of food, the elder's

"Where will my voice go?" and the complaint about a market-day clash restore life's multiple meanings.

Mausala Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Interim Narratological Assessment of Chapters 185–188

Four Markets, Four Kinds of Invisible Labour

The donation in Chapter 185, document correction in Chapter 186, food in Chapter 187 and tool-work in Chapter 188 are not four examples of one office procedure. Suraj's climbing, Rekha's bangles, Rukhsana's mornings and evenings, and Harinarayan's anvil create distinct times of labour. The expense of meals donated for workers does not erase market labour; consent written on a photocopy does not establish real land rights; additional names for plates do not produce grain; and an ominous photograph of an ordinary hook is not testimony to its ultimate use. Their different material scenes prevent the story-world from becoming a single-threaded sermon. (Chapters 185–188)

The reach of Jharna's decisions as new chairperson remains restrained in each chapter. She examines the donation conditions; Tara admits an error on her own side; rules are empty without Rukhsana's resistance; and Harinarayan personally bears the risk of losing clients. Rather than serial victories under one "saviour," there is a distributed arrangement of several active centres of decision. (Chapters 185–188)

The Place of Brief Scenes from Ancient Dvaraka

The donor at the bridge in Chapter 185, the elderly cook in Chapter 187 and the metal vessel without a named worker in Chapter 188 become independent, complete or incomplete, ancient work stories. Chapter 186 concerns the modern annual festival at the mouth of a watercourse, not an independent ancient interval featuring Krishna and Balarama. It would be wrong to impose an artificially identical two-time structure upon all four chapters. The ancient incidents are not the origins of modern documents, but parallel readerly experiences of social tensions. (Chapters 185–188)

Returning objects—the vessel, bottle, lantern, handkerchief and sealed chest—gain their meanings through different uses within the narrative. One must avoid inflating metaphor and assess material labour by its concrete measures. (Chapters 185–188)

Incomplete Outcomes and Internal Criticism

Completed outcomes include agreement to limited conditions on the donation, Tara's withdrawal of the false annotation, Rukhsana's first

scheduled day of rest, Nandlal's advance for one ploughshare, Amina's payment for meals, and Rekha's limited test. Outstanding matters include Devavrat's old consignment, Jhingri's wages, the earlier copying of Rekha's design, the kitchen's long-term budget, the source of the anonymous chest, and Harinarayan's debts. The text leaves this difference genuinely open. (Chapters 185–188)

Many lines in collective discussions are procedurally flawless and carefully arranged, reducing the space for emotional eruptions in individual characters. Rukhsana's thin flatbread for herself and Ajit's little nail disrupt the excessively polished rhythm of policy language. Criticism must retain these limitations alongside the chapters' achievements. (Chapters 185–188)

Mausala Parva / Uttara Kanda: Comprehensive Narratological Assessment of Chapters 181–192

From the Festival of Colours Through Disintegration to Reconstruction

Mausala Parva begins with the festival platform, Deepak's trembling body, the memorial contract, and the transfer of keys from Ruhani to Jharna (Chapters 181–184). The middle sequence—conditions on a gift, Tara's error, kitchen labour and the tool market—reveals the true cost of institutional change (Chapters 185–188). In the final four chapters Balarama withdraws from the shadow of his own leadership; Krishna dies from Jara's arrow after strife among the Yadavas; modern pond-clearing proceeds with mixed success; and the danger of a new monopoly over records arises (Chapters 189–192). This sequence is not merely a linear diagram of decline, but a structure in which the differing times of living flow together.

Violence within the dynasty cannot be fully explained by a miraculous destiny attached to former glory. Within the mythic name of the reed-pestle are human hands that actually strike, incomplete testimony and care for the wounded. The narrator does not merge Krishna's death, as divine retribution, with Naira's death in the modern story. The refusals of Sarita and Kabir establish limits upon the parva's mythical extension. (Chapters 189–190)

The share of scenes situated in ancient Dvaraka gradually grows. The intermittent ancient openings of Chapters 181–188 give way in Chapter 189 to Balarama's substantial nine-unit temporal sequence; Chapter 190 concentrates Krishna's death in thirteen ancient textual units. Chapters 191 and 192 remain wholly within modern narrative time. The sequence does

not prove an immediate continuity of social life from the destroyed royal family to the contemporary community. Instead it asks how ordinary work proceeds in one era after the catastrophe represented in another.

Balarama's choice not to raise his mace and Nazir's attention to correct measurements for a chisel do not instantiate one identical individual duty; they belong to different persons and institutions. Nor are Krishna's arrow and modern safety agreements for a forest route a direct causal pair. Their resemblance is resonance produced by narrative reading, not verification of literal history. (Chapters 189–190)

Narrative Time, the Emergence of Objects, and Character Agency

Most modern chapters unfold across the bounded hours from morning to night, but older debts, allegations from years before, annual clearing of waterways and future dates of review open divergent paths through time. The reader encounters at once an immediate patient's meal, months of accounting inquiry, generations of occupational learning and the persistence of grief after a death. The composition gains critical energy from the difference between the dated time of documents and the experienced time of bodily exhaustion.

Keys, wheels, plates, photocopies, lac bangles, a sealed chest, an overturned plate, a wooden boat, a child's unfinished pond picture and three coloured threads all perform distinct narrative tasks. To turn every unresolved object into a universal symbol would be harmful. Rukhsana's private bread, Kutiladevi's demand for the name of her missing grandson, Jara's error of perception and Sabina's price for her first repaired net possess exceptional human density even without being made into emblematic objects.

The Achievement of Polyphony and the Reader's Burden of Over-Explanation

Although Jharna is chairperson, she does not monopolise decisions. Ruhani retains the memory of her earlier authority; Mahendra repeatedly voices objections; Tara names her own error. Rukhsana, Saqib, Karun, Suraj, Salim, Durga, Madhuri, Gomati and Sabina intervene from their particular economic situations. It would be inadequate to list their voices merely as representatives of neglected castes and classes: each frames conditions about labour, risk, price and dignity.

The limit of this achievement is that the novel almost always supplies an ethically correct formulation of rules immediately in each situation. Some dialogue leaves little room for natural hesitation, misunderstanding or contradictory private desire. But Tara's fear, Shyam's refusal of easy forgiveness, Ruhani's emptiness, Nandu's dissent, Kutiladevi's demand for a single name and Sabina's unwillingness to become an example are

important exceptions. Narratological criticism must retain both the achievement and the limitation together.

The Actual Conclusion of Mausala Parva

At Chapter 192 the remaining decision over Devavrat's long-term donation, the original ledger of the old consignment, broader forest rights, compensation for Suraj Gangota, Phulmati's damaged net, Sabina's permanent livelihood and formal suspension of the archive tender are all unresolved. The third clearing has opened a safe portion of the landing, Ramsakhi's payment has arrived, and testing of community copies has begun: these are concrete achievements. "Not everything has broken" is true in the text only with this unevenness, not as a universal proclamation of recovery.

Taken as a whole, Mausala Parva is not merely a tale of the erosion of individual heroism. It is an artistic examination of how questions about whose name, whose labour and whose right to retain a copy of one's own record spread into future public life. The assessment of the following Mahaprasthanika Parva must examine the remaining answers through its original text, rather than impose them upon the present of Chapter 192.

Mahaprasthanika Parva / Uttara Kanda

Chapter 193 — The Announcement of the Journey

The Weight of the Crown and the Incomplete Opening of the Great Departure

The scene of the crown weighing heavily upon Parikshit's head does not turn the opening of Mahaprasthanika Parva into a passionless mantra of renunciation. Yudhishthira's hand is steady but not free from anxiety; the protection of the young heir, Yuyutsu's administrative experience, and Subhadra's authority over the coming generation are discussed before the abdication. The voluntary journey of those who renounce and the involuntary obligations of those left behind become two unequal temporalities of the same event. In the ancient narrative strand, the presentation of a policy decision here opens questions of the city's orphans, fields and tax collection beyond the hero's internal conflict.

Draupadi feels the presence of a decision within her own feet; the brothers' bodies, too, do not move in a single emotional register. Arjuna's invisible bow, Bhima's memory of the stairs, Sahadeva's exhaustion with calculation, and Nakula's soldierly gaze give the collective journey multiple centres. The dog follows, but the narrator does not yet impose any definitive significance upon its future role. The distinct impressions made by the bodies may foreshadow the falls to come, yet in this first chapter they signify only the unequal experiences of individual travellers.

The Village Square in 2042: The Art of the Cut from Epic to Modernity

In the sixth textual segment the scene cuts to Tara Mallik's empty box in the square at Videhapur in the year 2042. In place of the crown in the ancient royal palace come dry clothes, copies of papers, fares and receipts. The cut moves readers between two distant periods without making the Pandavas' journey the cause of the modern records team's existence. On one side stands civic responsibility before renunciation; on the other, the work of returning records to the people's hands before the funds run out. Both can be read as parallel narrative reflections.

The municipal office has planned visits to four places, but the wet path across the square, an old map, the hour when people return from their fields, and the school timetable obstruct the plan. An elderly worker distinguishes municipal permission from the right to use a shared path. A child looks for medicine in the box of papers; Sarita offers no false hope.

The dramatic duration of a single day seems prolonged because of repeated postponements: it is not the vehicle's timetable but the rhythms of the listeners' lives that determine the narrative's actual pace.

The Meeting beneath the Peepal: The Right to Question and the Reader's Expectations

Two women and a young man choose to sit in the shade of the peepal rather than inside the school. Two days of Urāhi's outstanding wages, a field being eroded by water, and the risk of publicly printing a person's name constitute three distinct narrative problems. Gomati does not promise immediate payment of an old claim; she explains the separate value of providing a copy of the rules and a route to a hearing. Through this scene, 'delivering the paper' ceases to be a single event of success and becomes the social process of 'reading the paper and asking questions.'

There is no dry chest in the house; who will hold the key, and how will an illiterate person understand a copy? Such questions give the abstract publicity of the archive a location, a climate, an educational setting and a requirement of security. The public papers are eventually placed in a locked school cupboard, while the selection of a local custodian for private papers is postponed until the next meeting. It would be inappropriate to call this a 'complete transfer of three copies': one component of the programme has been accomplished, but an important decision about the local shared arrangement remains.

Focalisation and the Narration of Naira's Absence

Sarita carries not Naira's blue bag but a bag she has sewn herself. She feels the emotional pressure of imagining what her daughter might have done had she lived, yet she does not write that possibility as a new sentence supposedly spoken by the daughter. Saying, 'I am listening,' Sarita acknowledges her grief and returns her attention to the question of unpaid wages. The narrator reaches her inner experience without manufacturing an interview with the absent Naira's consciousness; this restraint gives the focalisation of grief its particular form.

Tara objects both to the municipal demand for publicity material and to the proposal for a group photograph without consent. The decision to record the transfer at one location instead of three creates a numerical irony about achievement. The notation 'Awaiting consent' becomes a new signification within the narrative: a disappointing count and a correct procedure are not measured by the same standard. Yet nearly every active character speaks the language of privacy with unusual clarity; such ordered dialogue can sometimes diminish the spontaneous confusion of conflict.

The Open Question of the Watercourse and the Chapter's Ending

On the city's map the watercourse is marked closed; in the settlement, water cuts through it again after the rains. The elder's insistence—not to give a single day's observation a permanent significance for two years—discloses the plot's local scale of time. Tara writes, 'Seasonal inspection required.' Thus the duration of a scene and the river's recurring time remain within each other's limits; the narrator feels no need to make the river an all-encompassing symbol of mystery.

On the final page the list grows longer although the box has been emptied: the postponed visit, the wage claim, inspection of the watercourse, and protection of private details. 'Final visit' was the administration's designation, not an event marking the end of the people's troubles. From the Pandavas' journey at the opening emerges a metaphorical question—who can carry the responsibilities of those still alive after others depart?—but the modern settlement fashions its answer through its own events and decisions.

Chapter 194 — Draupadi's Path

The Torn Knot: The Epic Heroine's Embodied Present

Draupadi removes a thorn from her torn clothing; the grand journey through the snow begins with a necessary small repair. Bhima's bag holds no needle, only the food that remains. Thirst, pain in the knees, wind and brief halts make the journey's time tangible. 'I ask not for an explanation, but for a little rest,' Draupadi says, refusing to let her body's need become guilt before the group's decision. In this ordinary dialogue the character's agency exists independently of the epic's divine epithets.

At the beginning the knot in the torn garment is an immediate task she performs herself; its being pulled loose again at the end is not the unsuccessful abandonment of a lifetime's labour, but a scene of renewed effort. One object binds the opening and closing—a narrative circularity—yet to make it the sole metaphor for Draupadi's entire personality would repeat precisely the single-cause interpretation that the novel tests.

The Nonchronological Return of Memory: The Many Times of One Life

Cold water summons the memory of Indraprastha's Maya Sabha, behind whose splendour appear the nameless hands that filled its pitchers. The sound of utensils on a later morning in Panchala differs from the celebrated scene of the swayamvara; the dice hall, wet timber during exile, the distinct laughter of dead sons, and an uneasy intimacy with Subhadra

form separate circles of memory. These analepses are no summary of a crowned person's biography, but fragments of a life gradually disclosed by present thirst and weariness of bone.

Draupadi herself admits that neither her anger nor her decisions were always just. Through this admission the narrator does not idealise every act of a woman: room remains for contradiction, jealousy, mistaken words, sorrow and laughter to coexist. There is a risk in places of making an ancient character a ready-made spokesperson for a modern manifesto, but the singular memories of hunger and thirst disrupt the uniformity of the dialogue.

The Unanswered Question of the Dice Hall: Against a One-Sentence Biography

Arjuna acknowledges that he may have mistaken his victories for sound decisions; Yudhishthira perceives the distance between uttering the words of dharma and understanding people's lives. Draupadi asks: 'If someone were to state the final reason for my life in a single word,' whose choice would that word be? This is also a comment upon narrative itself: what authority over narration decides a character's fixed meaning after death? If only a man's explanation supplies the answer, the woman's own long experience is cut away.

Beyond the mythic effect of the protection of her garment in the dice hall, Draupadi keeps alive the ethical question of the principal humiliation; anger at that moment and the question it raised are not identical. In the conventional account of the great departure, affection for Arjuna is named the 'cause of her fall.' The original chapter does not deny that affection, but refuses its monopoly amid grief for her sons, forest life, and decisions made without political authority. In displacing the conventional answer, the narrative does not provide a false new final answer.

Focalisation, the Falling Body and Narrative Distance

Yudhishthira walks ahead while Bhima is near Draupadi's body: this spatial division figures the distance between the one who gives a moral explanation and the one who hears the heat of a falling body. After the stone slips, Draupadi tries twice to steady herself; before Bhima's hand can reach her, her body touches the ground. By extending scene time, the narrator prevents the act of dying from becoming a swift example attached to a sermon.

In the last moments Yudhishthira's explanation in terms of partiality is heard, but Draupadi understands its insufficiency through her own memories. Looking at the torn knot, Bhima registers the fact of a small repair. Yudhishthira's answer is the statement of a character within the

story; it would be a mistake to treat it as the impartial judgment of the narrator about the entire story-world. This shift in centres creates a conflict of voices inside the familiar Mahaprasthana narrative.

Artistic Achievement and Limitation

Stone, the absence of a needle, a sip of water from deep below, and a half-remembered song prevent death from becoming merely a static image of karuna-rasa. The reader grasps the difference between a life seen with the eyes and a life held in the hands. Draupadi does not convene a complete tribunal of justice at the end; nor does an omniscient verdict issue on her behalf. Thus the light knot at the opening becomes an exceptionally dense scene of representation at the close.

Nevertheless, the explicit recurrence of the question 'Who has the right to tell a story?' sometimes reduces the space available for the reader to form a meaning; on several occasions characters express their self-analysis in distinctly critical language. Despite this stylistic risk, the scene of death and falling, Bhima's helpless hand, and Draupadi's final silence remain beyond the full control of any one 'correct reading.' The silence that remains gives the chapter its independent narratological depth.

Chapter 195 — The Distance between the Brothers

The Diminishing Group: The Temporal Design of a Series of Deaths

Having left Draupadi behind, Sahadeva tries to count the distances between them, but Bhima's question—are everyone's feet alike?—reveals the impossibility of a uniform pace. Sahadeva's slipping, Nakula's helping hand and the passing of a staff initiate the scene of death. Yudhishthira speaks of pride in intellect as its cause; Sahadeva's final bodily experience, however, remains independent of that single sentence. This separation between a 'reason for the journey' and a person's lived life advances the argument of Chapter 194.

Two staffs in Nakula's hands, the breaking reflection in a stream, the futile calling of Sahadeva's name and the recollection of unqualified praise for beauty: in this sequence the character's fall is complicated by grief rather than becoming an instant lesson in morality. Arjuna's palm without Gandiva, his unfulfilled promises in battle and his wish to say 'brother' rather than 'warrior' form the next change of rhythm. Narration repeatedly diminishes the group's numerical shape—five brothers, three, two, one—yet fresh memories enter each diminishing number.

Bhima's Hunger and Yudhishthira's Final Solitude

After an immeasurable past, Bhima says, 'I am hungry.' The immediate meaning of the sentence is an ordinary bodily need; to read it as predetermined proof of greed and the cause of his fall would deny the character's present. A crack in the rock, straining muscles and pain in the chest render death physical; Yudhishthira draws close and takes his hand. In this moment of intimacy there is severe tension between religious explanation and a family's final conversation.

At the end the dog remains, but is not made a speaker of divine argument. It needs water; its body can continue moving. Yudhishthira shares the water that remains. This small act preserves a living relationship independent of the clamour of the death sequence's lofty pronouncements about dharma. Even after completing the succession of deaths the narrator does not make it a hierarchy of answers, because immediate suffering cannot be wholly contained in a final formula of causation.

Javed's Curtain: An Abrupt Modern Change of Scene

In the twenty-seventh textual segment the scene cuts to the courtyard of the shelter at Videhapur. Javed Kalandar has abandoned his old performances with live animals and is making a new art of cloth birds, paper monkeys and shadows. After the ancient deaths in the snow, the children's question—'No monkey?'—is no moral replica of the death sequence; it is an independent narrative axis involving the actual economic crisis of performance. The collision of unlike scenes asks what livelihood remains after renunciation, without making ancient characters the authors of modern art.

In Javed's new programme a paper monkey shares food with a small hungry puppet. Two spectators who want a 'real trick' get up and leave. The cloth scene becomes a story for children, but its market price declines. Here the performer's internal focalisation—fear, trembling hands, his resolve not to bring back the old animals—makes the personal cost of ethical change palpable.

The Dramatic Account of One Hundred and Eighteen Rupees

The performance brings in 118 rupees; after 40 for cloth and bamboo, 32 for travel and 20 for Anshu's wages, Javed has 26 rupees left. Through these four figures the plot situates artistic freedom within questions of labour time and minimum income. Javed accepts that a performance without animals is possible, but does not claim that the proceeds will support a household. His resolve to agree on the time, venue and minimum fee before the next show is a future contract, not a completed economic success.

Anshu receives his payment for assisting and makes protection of his study hours a condition. Chandra criticises the old phrase 'magical animals' on the poster. Performer, child assistant, singer and organiser are not a single voice imitating one ethical model; each intervenes from the distinct cost of their labour. As a symbol the torn wing of the curtain matters, but its actual repair and the correction of professional language are equally necessary for the reader.

Evaluation: Proportion and Narrative Risk

The ancient strand gives the sequence of deaths an intense extension of time; the modern strand covers several hours of performance and an income calculation. Their renewed contact is only a thematic possibility—the obligations of the lives that remain after others have been left behind—not an established historical relation.

One limitation is that the traditional explanations for each fall continually enter the sequence of ancient brothers; the narrator explicitly calls upon the reader to interpret them through the complexity of distinct lives. Yet Bhima's hunger, Arjuna's 'brother,' Nakula's staff and the concrete, partial outcome of Javed's twenty-six rupees lend these theoretical statements their own rhythm of experience.

Chapter 196 — Fakira's Station

A Corrected Identity, Uncorrected Working Time

Fakira tests the raised iron plate at the station's goods entrance with the point of his walking stick. His travel pass has been corrected after the register declared him dead, yet the different designations 'Sai Fakir' and 'Fakira' raise questions again for the contractor at the new station. The completed result of one administrative correction does not automatically secure an allocation of work in another institution. The plot thus begins in the incomplete use of a right already won, not in some new global conspiracy.

The goods supervisor expects him to remain available without payment from morning until evening. Fakira offers to wait for two hours until noon at a fixed rate, but refuses unlimited availability. The guard's shift is written down; the labourer's is not. This inequality calls into question the worker's narrative authority over his own day. Fakira does not achieve a great victory immediately after delivering a heroic speech: he obtains limited work and several disputed items.

Boxes, Sacks and Weight: Labour in Action

He refuses to accept a new rate for lifting an additional heavy box without a separate charge, and insists on checking the actual weight of two sacks to be carried jointly. These small actions keep the risks of labour tangible within the story. A young assistant wants to earn quickly; Fakira's caution does not nullify his economic impatience. The manager cannot make Fakira undertake the undefined extra work with the box, and consequently no payment is made for its handling. It would be incorrect in criticism to describe this as withheld wages: the work has neither been accepted nor performed.

A separate contract is made to carry Nandu Nat's bamboo platform and bundles of cloth; Fakira retightens a loose knot in the rope. A failure in work is not merely a loss of personal income; it can become a bodily danger for someone else. The old occupational skill keeps the scene from turning into a linear story of 'rehabilitating a beggar.' An active professional personality emerges among the station labourer, the assistant in travel and the traditional Nat troupe.

Hasan and Zubaida's Separate Counter-Narrative

Beside the bus stand Hasan has not received a permanent lease for his repair table, but permission for a limited temporary period. Responding to an objection, Zubaida points out that fifteen minutes of the permitted time remain; when she notices the actual danger from a moving bus wheel, however, she moves the table herself. The scene does not construct the easy counter-position that 'officials are always wrong': a limited adjustment occurs between safety measures and the right to conduct a business, without resolving permanent ownership.

The mention of Zubaida's seven-day, limited stitching and repair arrangement and her job at different hours in the shelter matters. She is not present simply to support Fakira's story; she keeps the customer's fee, responsibility, her own shift and independent earnings distinct. Hasan answers the dismissive address 'old Bakho' by demonstrating his repair skills. Rather than replying to stigma with extraordinary heroism, the narrator does so through actual work performed in the scene.

Sound, Memory and Narrative Time

The railway bell, the striking of a stick and the fragment of a song heard from his mother are separate particles of memory within Fakira's present. He does not know the raga's name, but a portion of its tune survives. The uncertainty of music here is not simply a failure of archival verification; private time has its own continuity. A question about two sounds of iron on a certain old night arises at the end, but Fakira does not accuse anyone

he did not see. This indication keeps the mystery sequence moving without allowing it to take possession of the story of the day's earnings.

In the last scene Sarita and Fakira take different paths, one towards the station and the other towards the old veranda of the kitchen. Even when Naira's loss is recalled, Fakira does not turn it into an entry pass for every conversation. The original text keeps clear the difference between the dog's footprints in the Mahaprasthanika scene and any evidence on modern soil. By refusing that narrative identification, the chapter prevents modern public life from becoming an obedient follower of the epic's commands.

Critical Outcome

The corrected travel pass, money received for unloading two sacks, and the arrangement to carry Nandu's bundles are settled outcomes. Verification of payment for waiting time and of the claim for missed earnings remains open; Hasan has not secured a permanent lease; Zubaida's small enterprise continues. The distinction among complete, partial and pending changes is essential to the story's organisation.

One limitation is that the workers' dialogue is often unusually alert to calculations and faultless procedure. Nevertheless, the customer's contempt, the young man's impatience, an actual bus turning, and the incomplete cadence of Fakira's memory open uncomfortable human intervals in this densely argumentative rhythm.

Chapter 197 — The First Room

The Opening Door, the Story of a Prohibition and Uncertain Ownership

Sarita herself unlocks the old kitchen of the shelter. Dust, a tin container, cord and a chalk-marked sheet are the opening scene's objects; on seeing a blue bag, Sarita does not immediately decide that it belonged to her dead daughter Naira. The narrator sensitively portrays the possibility of misrecognition in grieving eyes: an object is not necessarily what a person longs to see. In this way, the difference between memory and visible truth enters the plot's arrangement of objects.

Rukhsana's two-hour availability, Zubaida's warm water and the sequence of the cleaning list establish a measured pace for the story. Three piles of cloth—the public kitchen register, objects of uncertain ownership, and private notebooks and envelopes connected with Naira—are not the final classification of a life, but a practical separation for today. A fourth category, 'Owner or context unclear,' is added later. The inventory is a provisional narrative device that preserves decisions for the future.

Urmila's Shift: The Distance between an Archival Date and a Debt

A torn page records the hours of Urmila's nighttime dishwashing, but that alone does not prove that her full wages were paid. Urmila, too, has died, and the balance due to her family remains unresolved. Sarita preserves a verifiable copy of the work page for an inquiry into payment. Within the same object, the scene thus presents the public need to document a deceased person's labour and the unequal obligation to protect that person's private life.

Naira's notebook sets out the sequence in which shelter rooms received too little water, alongside a woman's private sentence. Zubaida suggests comparing the public tap ledger so that water distribution can be checked without circulating private distress. The original narrative rejects both extreme alternatives—tearing up the original notebook or revealing everything. A third course is established through recording specified page numbers for controlled use.

The Demand for a Photograph and the Mother's Lack of Ownership

There is a proposal to send donors Naira's face and the story of her life. The employee's enthusiasm is not wholly malicious, but Sarita insists that the costs of rice, workers' wages, repairs and approved public work be sent separately. 'I am her mother' does not mean 'I own everything private about her': this reply rejects the easy presumption that grief entails hereditary possession of another person's story.

The seal on the private envelope is not broken, and the addressee is not clear. Kabir is informed, but is not given an immediate right to possess the envelope. A distinction is maintained between possible work-related information on the phone and curiosity about private messages. The reader wants to know, but the narration deliberately refrains from disclosure. This withholding is an ethical narrative decision, not the secret door of an ordinary thriller.

An Independent Cut to Simatirtha: Translation and the Missing Time of Transit

In the fifteenth segment the setting shifts to Simatirtha. Maitri Shrestha's old Nepali dispatch note, its Hindi translation and the hospital's blank receipt ledger tell different stories about the medicine consignment. 'Released for transport' had been incorrectly translated as 'Received at hospital'; Kumudi corrects it. Between the recorded date of dispatch and the date of physical receipt at the hospital lies an unobserved interval of the journey—translation cannot fill that missing time.

A correction recording Kumudi's name, working days and fee is approved; the money had been available but held under an incorrect budget head. The storekeeper finds two old receipts recording seal counts, although one interval in the temperature-protection record remains blank; the medicines are not assumed to have remained entirely sound. In this event sequence, the translator's credit, payment procedure and actual pharmaceutical quality are three separate outcomes. The modern cut away from Sarita's room is not a mere coincidence: in both places the structure requires opening the necessary portion of a paper while leaving an unresolved gap intact.

The Scene's Ending and Its Limited Achievement

In the evening an employee revises the public letter to donors: Naira's photograph is omitted, and the expenditure heads and payment dates are supplied instead. The envelope remains safe; page numbers are listed for some public documents; a payment date is fixed, but the full outstanding amount has not arrived. The plot does not unravel the room's entire past; it places responsibility for certain objects where it properly belongs.

The central question in Sarita's dialogue with Kabir is 'What do you decide?' Kabir chooses for now to keep his unsent letter private. Respect for the dead woman's private life and the living man's right to his own private letter coexist in the same exchange without being treated as identical. As a scene, the 'room' is not a metaphor for an imprisoned consciousness, but a physical place with separate exits for public work and personal relationships.

Chapter 198 — The Dead Person's Phone

The Closed Device and Narrative Temptation

The chapter opens with a demand to use Naira's phone publicly. Those organising a memorial event want to construct an 'intimate' portrait of the dead woman from her private messages; Sarita and Kabir distinguish public work records from personal exchanges. The story does not reveal the phone screen to the reader, but makes its external identification, place of storage and a proposal to unlock it into a dramatic scene. The centre of mystery moves from 'What is written inside?' to 'Who has permission to read what is inside?'

The secretary puts the camera back in the bag, but does not abandon the argument that private life might offer inspiration. Kabir admits that even as Naira's companion he did not know the answers to all her questions. This limited knowledge is not simply a failure of the relationship; it is also another person's freedom. A brief exchange about Shabnam's kheer and

today's kitchen budget preserves the independent, material urgency of food amid the emotional weight of the memorial proposal.

Rafiq's Self-Identification: A Parallel Narrative in a Living Voice

In Rafiq's identity paper the name of a language and a community identification had been merged into one 'Surjapuri' field. He asks for the right to write them as separate terms. The local supplementary register is given two separate fields, although the government master form cannot immediately be altered in that room. The distance between acknowledging receipt of a correction and changing an entire system is the original text's decisive open outcome. The utterance of a living person, messages of someone deceased, and the classifications of an institution occupy different positions here; it is insufficient to combine them into the single label 'identity problem.'

Rafiq's spoken 'Saura' (सउरा) and the official copy's 'Saurā' (सौरा) are two sources, while the 'Lalbageya' of Maitri's dispatch paper is a third, independent text. The appealing title 'The River Naira Found' might erase the distinction among sources, so Rafiq refuses to become the searcher in somebody else's story. Here the novel examines the style of emotional reminiscence itself: exaggerated attribution in the name of honouring the dead can distort the very care that person took.

Kabir's Focalisation and the Private Space of Memory

Kabir remembers Naira's irony, the mud of the rains and ordinary moments. The narrator consciously separates private memory from lines actually written on the original phone. Kabir can recount his own recollections, but does not assume the right to read at a meeting messages Naira wrote to someone else. His love consequently becomes not a gloriously omniscient entitlement, but an experience of his own limits.

Rukhsana's unpaid wages and Zubaida's questions enter the story of the phone; the important narrative criticism of the proposal to open a private device arises precisely when public labour records are already available. The temptation to make a dead life into a 'final sentence' expresses a desire for closure in narratives of death. The characters put a limited restraint on that appetite for last words.

The Actual Decision in the Scene and the Unfinished Future

The condition of the phone's exterior is recorded; the device is placed in a securely closed box, and joint custodial signatures are obtained. Kabir expressly adds that he has not consented to publication of the messages inside. Advice on technical preservation is a possibility for the future, not

permission to open the contents. A proposal to draft an alternative version of the memorial event is accepted; the event itself has not yet been fixed.

On the last night Kabir keeps his unsent envelope closed. The ordinary act of dimming a bulb for moths outside gives visible form to an appropriate limit on affection, against the demand to 'open every door.' The artistic force of this small action involving an object is more natural than a direct statement of doctrine. The chapter does not end in a sentimental final speech; between the closed phone and the irreversible fact of Naira's death, it leaves the responsibilities of the living.

Narrative Limitation

The narrator makes many characters formulate principles of privacy, credit and limits with remarkable orderliness. When every proposition in literary dialogue receives an immediately suitable response, some of the awkwardness of a living scene may be lost. Nevertheless, Kabir's handkerchief, Shabnam's kheer and Rafiq's piece of jaggery sustain individual voices and embodied lives amid ethical debate.

From the sealed envelope in Chapter 197 to the closed phone in Chapter 198, the technology of the object changes but not the basic conflict. This is not a pure opposition of paper and digital devices: it concerns displaced rights over public use, personal relationships and the recognised limits of a source. Because of that continuity the new chapter is not a new mystery, but a more exacting extension of an older question. (Chs. 197–198)

Chapter 199 — A Story without a Name

The Scene's Opening with a Thread-Tied Envelope

There is no name on the envelope, only the words 'For a story.' The visitor does not theatrically conceal their face, but requires that identifying details of home and work not be made public. Consent to tell a story and permission to publish one's identity are different things—a distinction established at the start of the scene. The experience of a house name being printed in an earlier preliminary list supplies a social reason for fear. The reader is led to ask who controls authorship, editing and the published version of written words.

Padma sets aside three sheets: an authorised statement, documents that may be checked, and limits on publication. Two days of hours were left blank in the speaker's labour register, but the speaker does not have the original. What the person saw is their testimony; they did not directly see who was actually employed in place of the listed worker. The statement sheet and the administrative verification sheet are prepared separately. This

distinction must not be called an automatic guarantee of the story's authenticity: a procedure has begun, not a final determination of the allegation.

Poonam's Second Narrative Strand: The Intrusion of an Ancestral Name

Poonam Chidimar is presently sewing jute covers for the kitchen. Enthusiasm for making an image of her ancestral community's hunting practices risks misrepresenting her current craft. She rejects the caption 'Traditional Chidimar trap' for a photograph because customers could misunderstand her work. Through this small act of resistance a classified community appears not merely as an object of historical study but as an active character choosing the meaning of its present market activity.

Padma places the approved portions of oral memory and a detailed material description of present-day sewing on two separate pages. Poonam's ancestral ring, the thick jute thread and the finished cover are not automatically complete symbols within the story; they are implements of actual work. A payment date is fixed, but there is no event in which the money has already reached her bank account. Respect for the past and the price of work in the present retain their distinct temporalities.

Somri's Language and the Pressure of Contract Time

Somri Hembram brings a draft of the principal conditions in Santali. The contractor's representative warns that the working season may pass, while a young man in debt needs earnings quickly. Patience in checking the translation against the immediate need for wages prevents the scene from becoming a debate between predetermined virtues. Somri asks for separate payment for translation work; written approval for the first instalment is obtained, but the full checking of the text remains unfinished.

Rukhsana's kitchen cover and Somri's contract carry different economic rhythms within the same room. The first is an immediate product, the second the labour of preventing future risk. Neither Poonam nor Somri serves merely as an auxiliary example for an anonymous narrator: the customers, markets and payments attached to their work differ. Social polyphony emerges through these independent narrative strands, not through diversity of vocabulary alone.

Panar–Parola: The Non-Joining of Different Sources

In Rafiq's speech 'Panar' is the spoken form, while Maitri's old transport paper records 'Parola.' Kumudi draws two parallel lines on her sheet, with no arrow joining them. The scene has a particular meaning for narrative form: prose can hold several story threads at a slight distance from one

another, while a reader's liking for metaphor may want to turn them all into the route of a single river. The story immediately checks that premature joining.

Separate dates, pronunciations and written forms matter for protection. Yet the young man becomes impatient with these distinctions: is a story to be printed, or only a warning? Sarita's reply raises a genuine aesthetic question within the text: can an excess of caution slow the independent movement of storytelling? The author's characters choose consent, but the presence of an impatient voice prevents the controversy from becoming wholly monologic.

Approved Printing, Blank Spaces and the Plot's Open Ending

Padma reads the approved draft aloud; the speaker changes two sentences. Permission is given for a limited reading at the community school and anonymous printing in a booklet; photographs, sound recordings and disclosure of identity are refused. A separate request is sent for the original labour register. The limits of publication have thus been settled; the person responsible for omitted hours in the register, the actual payment and the order to make a correction remain undecided.

At the end, the visitor takes back a length of thread to tie up the notebook at home. Telling a story while keeping the mouth of the paper tied is the scene's dramatic conclusion, not a miracle. Padma's blank sheet with four compartments anticipates the following chapter. Here 'blank' means more than an error: decisions not yet made, conversations to come and limits imposed by sources all retain their places.

Chapter 200 — The Final Examination of Words

Four Narrow Slips: Narrative Form Made Present in Its Own Text

Padma lays out four slips of paper marked 'Directly observed,' 'Heard,' 'Inferred' and 'Imagined.' They become a community teaching aid for distinguishing types of narration within the text. To treat them in themselves as a complete external philosophical apparatus for testing evidence would be an improper extension of the critical method. The principal narratological question is when the narrator shows the reader an event seen by a person, when a remembered account that has been heard, and when an imagined scene from a play.

Jagat wishes to stage the empty labour-register entry in his play. Padma does not forbid the imagination, but insists upon the limit that a fabricated criminal scene must not be laid against the identity of a real employee. Sarita distinguishes the truth of fear in drama from a false

accusation against a particular person. The narrative method therefore becomes not merely a classification of information, but a modern story-question about the propriety of literary imagination.

Asha Bhumij's Displacement: Separate Narrative Strands of Grief and Expense

Asha's tin box holds slips for rent, medicines, travel and lost earnings among families displaced from a mining area. An elderly woman's wish to return home is bound to fears for safety; another family has lost work despite staying without charge; a member of a third family is away earning money. Jagat's dramatic line, 'All homeless people have gone home,' is revised in the face of these different situations. The characters' unequal trajectories save the story from a deceptive single narrative of universal return.

Seeing the available receipts, hearing families recount their own suffering, and treating each expense as definitely caused by the mining operation are three different narrative positions. The third claim requires later investigation; putting an application for assistance on a hearing list is neither secured tenure nor completed return. No final revised compensation amount has been entered on Asha's separate copies. In this unfinished procedure, the social time of displacement resists the administrative classification's instant claim to completeness.

Tulsi's Strike: One Event, Two Different Narrative Endings

Transport workers remain on strike over unpaid shift allowances and rest periods. Faced with a request to move a hospital patient in special circumstances, the committee grants a limited exception: a written medical order, suitable vehicle, family consent, a specified time, risk allowance and a condition against carrying outside goods. Rather than making a simple opposition of 'humanity versus workers' rights,' the scene portrays the different urgencies of an individual patient and a collective movement.

The vehicle reaches the other centre; the outcome of the patient's treatment is private and unknown. The proprietor's representative wants to publicise the trip as 'the end of the strike,' but Tulsi refuses. Successful completion of an emergency journey and termination of industrial action are two distinct narrative outcomes. The driver eventually returns, while signatures for the additional journey allowance remain pending. These precise distinctions prevent the linguistic appropriation of the event's ending.

The River's Name and the Bamboo Knot: Distance between Translated Voices

A mistaken translation of Nasima's family term of address could change the identification of its recipient; Amir's three receipts bear different dates. 'Mahananda' is the wording of the original letter; to treat it as the certain name of a present economic route would be an inference. The spellings 'Chilon' and 'Chilaun' used by Shyam Mallik and Vinod Kevart likewise do not in themselves establish the boundaries of one and the same fishing-water right. In these episodes the narrator keeps separate the sound of a word, the time recorded on a page and the physical meaning of work.

A knot in Shyam's bamboo suggests the possibility of making several objects—a fish barrier, a basket or a woven walkway—but without differences of use and risk the knot has no single meaning. Jagat can write a song about it; the song will not thereby become the official boundary of a fishing right. This answer clearly distinguishes art from the methods of knowing land ownership: making art is not forbidden, but treating an invented scene as a historical measurement is improper.

Polyphony and Self-Criticism in the Community School

For the community reading it is decided that the anonymous person's story must be printed expressly as that person's stated experience; the editor has not personally seen the original labour register. The office's response merely acknowledges receipt of the application, not the existence of an irregularity. Jagat grows impatient again with this distinction; Padma asks him to test the narrative source of every page. Readers of stories are thereby encouraged to practise choosing the degree of their own trust.

One girl says she saw fish in the pond; another child recalls the fish her grandmother used to know; a third expresses fear of a possible flood. An elderly listener asks, 'What if I saw it, but understood it wrongly?' This question stops the four slips from becoming an unquestionable system. The paper categories clarify some things while leaving room for doubt about individual constructions of meaning.

Objects at the Close, the Limits of Narration and Criticism

At night Sarita winnows rice; Asha's rubber-banded box, Tulsi's strike cloth, Nasima's stitched book cover and Shyam's bamboo knot remain in their material places. The four terms do not make anyone the new owner of an object: they merely teach readers humility in understanding. The chapter does not contain all lives within a theoretical formula, but leaves distance between objects and accounts of them.

A limitation is that the educational demonstration of four distinctions risks making the mouths of many characters utter the same doctrinal lesson. Yet the strike's unpaid allowances, the different wishes of displaced families, uncertain river names and Jagat's imaginative impatience disclose conflicting life times in place of a lifeless page of moral categories. For this reason, the title's 'final examination' is not in fact a final truth; it opens an ongoing and responsible practice of examination for future readers.

Mahaprasthanika Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Narratological Assessment of Chapters 193–200

From Journey to Community School: The Parva's Narrative Movement

The parva begins with the transfer of succession; the ancient royal family leaves the kingdom (Ch. 193). Draupadi's fall (Ch. 194), the successive deaths of Sahadeva, Nakula, Arjuna and Bhima (Ch. 195), and the gradually expanding scenes of modern communal life (Chs. 196–200) then change the shape of the reader's experience of time. The 'great departure' does not mean simply that all the heroes leave: the narrative asks how public work, private words and unanswered obligations of livelihood survive among those who remain.

Explanatory Voices and the Multiplicity of Experience

The traditional explanations of Draupadi's partiality, Sahadeva's pride in intellect and Bhima's hunger enter through Yudhishthira's speech. Yet the narration tests their completeness through the body's last moments, a brother's affection, memories of dead sons and unanswered questions. The text exposes in its own structure the danger inherent in ending a person's entire life with the attribution of 'one fault.' (Chs. 194–195)

Modern characters—Sarita, Tara, Gomati, Rukhsana, Fakira, Zubaida, Javed, Rafiq, Padma, Asha, Tulsi, Poonam and Somri—are not representatives of a single narrative objective. Each has a distinct time limit, professional charge, protected private dimension and disputed outcome. Javed's remaining income of twenty-six rupees and the unequal return-home situations of displaced families ground characters in the costs of actual lives rather than in a general proclamation of justice. (Chs. 195–200)

Narrative Time, Analepsis and Editing across Two Periods

Draupadi's thirst opens analepses of Indraprastha, the dice hall, exile and grief for her sons. Nakula's staff and Arjuna's empty palm convert former martial grandeur into present weakness. On the modern side, unclear older

administrative viewpoints, dates, payment times and expectations of copies refuse to synchronise. Such frequently unequal movements of time cannot be made into a literal causal link of 'the rebirth of the past.'

In Chapter 197 the scene cuts from Sarita's room to the translation office at Simatirtha and then returns to the room. Rather than making events a single, unbroken classical time, this cut reveals them as multiple locations of lived experience.

Gaps, Withholding and the Narrative Functions of Objects

The future meaning of the dog's presence; the unfinished sentence in Draupadi's self-account; the custodian of the school's private box; the unrecorded period of the medicine consignment's temperature; Naira's unsent envelope and locked phone; an anonymous speaker's unproven allegation; and translated river names—these gaps are not all the same kind of mystery. Some open plots for the future, some remain closed out of respect for persons, and others demand a separate date of investigation. If criticism misses this difference, the actual craft of the material disappears into a general symbol of 'incompleteness.'

The crown, the knot in a garment, Sahadeva's staff, the theatre curtain, raised iron at the station, the blue bag, the phone box, the thread around an envelope and the four slips of paper all perform physical functions in particular chapters. Draupadi's knot is a repair made for one day; Fakira's slip concerns earning a wage; Naira's phone is a bounded device containing protected private memory; Padma's slips are educational objects. To dissolve them all into one universal philosophical sign would diminish the detailed workmanship of the narrative.

Readerly Trust, Dissent and the Risk of Didacticism

In many places the style of procedural caution sounds like a sermon voiced by the characters themselves. The impatience of student Jagat, the secretary's sentimental desire for a memorial, a young man's debt crisis, a contractor's anxiety about time and the office's request for publicity photographs could counter that homogeneous moral idiom. But the narrator often gives the central characters the correct reply immediately, which can narrow the reader's freedom of interpretation.

The counterweight to this risk lies in visible failures and open questions: distribution of copies at only one settlement, the very small amount of money Javed retains, Fakira's pending waiting-time allowance, ambiguous ownership of private objects in the room, Rafiq's unchanged central form, Asha's uncertain compensation, and Tulsi's continuing strike. These actual incompletions prevent the story from becoming an uninterrupted series of theoretical successes.

Interim Conclusion: The Boundary of the Next Four Chapters

The special achievement of these eight chapters is not merely a comparison between a fall upon a stone and a corrected line in a document; it is the portrayal of different rights to narration arising in different story times. Draupadi's many-lived experience, workers' hours, a mother's private refusal and a storyteller's imagination cannot be gathered into a single sentence of ownership. In that remaining resistance lies the parva's formal essence.

Chapter 201 — Farewell at Simatirtha

Planks, Sand, and the River's Everyday Time

At dawn in Simatirtha in 2042, Madhu Kewat loosens the old planks of a boat and sweeps away the sand. He finds both a lodged coin and the corner of a wet sheet of paper, but the recovered coin does not discharge the outstanding wages owed to Shanti Bote for unloading an earlier cargo. Contrary to the promise of "farewell" in the title, the opening does not celebrate the conclusion of a journey: it begins with an unsettled account of continuing earnings. The narrative distinguishes the material body of the boat, the time spent rowing, the labour of unloading sacks, and written acknowledgment. Before the river can become a beautiful prospect, the working day at its landing comes into view.

Madhu's preparation of separate columns for fares, cargo weight, unloading wages, and time during which the boat is held up is the scene's practical centre. The clerk worries that passengers will be frightened; the merchant argues that waiting at a border post is an "ordinary risk" of a boatman's occupation. These positions become openly opposed. Madhu asks why the price of his time should be calculated only by the oar when the boat does not even travel as far as the checkpoint. The question reveals the social distribution of time. Readers witness a rule being drafted, but the dispute must be defined before it can be resolved.

River Names and the Narrative Arrangement of Multiple Accounts

Two forms, "Gandak/Gandaki," appear in Shanti's ledger. The merchant's representative suggests that they indicate two consignments; Shanti displays the sack-binding marks and unloading register separately. The sound of a river's name and the number of consignments are not facts of the same narrative kind. The page bearing the name "Gohi" is likewise bound up with a young man's impatience to finish a provisional map; Madhu's questions halt the line he is drawing. Rather than turning uncertainty about objects and words into the narrator's all-purpose atmosphere of mystery, the passage makes it a question within a local accounting dispute.

Shanti's next correction gives the dispute practical force: recording "time the boat was held" is insufficient unless the order under which it was held is also identified. The merchant raises the possibility that waiting time could be exaggerated. Shanti proposes copies for both sides and a means of cross-checking them. Through direct dialogue, an uncertain administrative boundary becomes a visible conflict without the narrator having to explain everything. Yet an agreement written on the page must

not be taken to mean that every actual cost of waiting at the border post has been accepted.

The Brass Lock: A Household Story and the Right to Disagree

In the middle of the meeting over boat fares, a woman from a household belonging to the water committee arrives carrying a brass lock. The original loan, the instalments paid, and an additional claim for waiting have been entered on a single line; she separates them into three parts. Her unexpected arrival gives the river-labour narrative the different rhythm of domestic debt. She does not ask for the dishonest liberation of seeing her entire debt recorded as "zero." She can already imagine a later reader of the paper: the person who will repeat the demand for payment tomorrow.

Two copies of the receipt are prepared, but the household's private borrowing is not made public. Kumudi distinguishes the error of calling both the outstanding loan and an advance for the next consignment by the same word, "liability." A teenager from her household twice reminds her that it is time to eat. This small repetition demonstrates that examining debt must not become unlimited, unpaid labour performed through endless delay; the hour of a family's meal is itself a legitimate force capable of ending a scene. On the final page the brass lock returns to the chest, though the dispute has not received a final decision.

Chanda's Blue Bag and the Different Meanings of "Travel Is Possible"

Chanda Munda places secure documents inside a blue bag whose seams have come apart. Three distinct things lie on the table: confirmation of identity, acknowledgment of leaving a job, and travel papers. Permission to travel is complete although unpaid wages remain "under separate consideration." Formal eligibility recorded on paper is not the same as a person's decision to depart. Chanda makes clear that her pace differs from that of a young worker. When an elderly boatman asks whether "home is not home, after all," she answers that home is a possibility of residence, not a prize.

At the end a young man catches the bus immediately, while Chanda chooses her own time. Her bag is no decorative relic of an earlier blue memory; it is a portable place for self-determination and unpaid dues. The narrator does not turn her uncertain mind into a psychological weakness. Thus "farewell" becomes a plurality of desires: one group returns, another person does not yet leave, and someone else specifies the conditions of a future meeting.

The First Trial Consignment: Limited Achievement and Artistic Limits

Madhu and three members of the committee sign; a three-journey trial begins. Madhu removes overloaded cargo and checks children's safety on the first crossing. Shanti's earlier claim for unpaid wages remains attached; there is no complete agreement about the cost of waiting at the border checkpoint. The event reaches the limited stage of "a new rule brought into use," not "an old injustice abolished." The evening wind and the gleam of fish lend lyrical breadth to this labour-filled present.

The chapter's achievement lies in embodying questions of justice within different measures of people's time: the hours a boat is held, the pause for a household meal, the next instalment of a loan, and Chanda's independent departure. Its limitation is that Madhu, Shanti, Kumudi, and Padma repeatedly speak in exceptionally well-ordered procedural language, so that organic conflict may resemble a display of competence predetermined by the narrator. Yet the opposing voices, the unpaid amount, and the lock at the close prevent an uncomplicated triumphal ending.

Four Heads of Labour: From a Single Rate to Multiple Stories

The discussion of boat fares rests from the outset on Madhu's four-column sheet: passenger fare, weight of goods, unloading wages, and time spent held up. When the merchant's representative attempts to dismiss delay at the checkpoint as an ordinary occupational risk for the boatman, the dispute comes to concern ownership of time. Delay at the landing is no abstract administrative postponement; it is a real loss to the boat's next trip, the waiting workers, and passengers' other opportunities. In place of the old rate sheet, the new four-column form is an object that alters the movement of the narrative, giving different characters an opportunity to articulate the work they do.

Even after the agreement is signed, the narrative does not jump from "a rule was made" to "justice was achieved." Copies of the recorded time for both parties, written reasons for waiting, the separate unloading service, and the first three trial journeys all depend on their conditions. When the first evening consignment proves too heavy, Madhu has goods unloaded, causing an actual delay at the landing. But Shanti's earlier claim for unloading wages is not automatically paid under the new contract. The narration produces a kind of "ending" in which a new procedure has begun while the time of the old debt remains stubbornly unchanged.

The Household Lock and the Travel Paper: The Structure of Unequal Departures

A woman arriving from a household associated with the water committee sets a brass lock on the table. In her entrance, home, debt, drainage, and

the office ledger collide in one visible space. Because the principal, two paid instalments, and an additional demand have occupied one line, her power to speak about her own household is diminished. Instead of demanding a false statement that she has no debt, she accepts “reconciliation pending.” The narrative achievement is not that she makes everyone forgive the debt but that the immediate pressure to sign for the entire alleged balance is stopped. The lock returns to the chest at the end. Its closure is not merely a symbol of silence but an image of the family's right over private records.

A second difficulty of departure emerges between Chanda Munda's fraying blue bag and the paper marked “travel possible.” The employee's receipt stamp has not paid Chanda's old wages, and the physical possibility of returning home does not compel her to depart immediately. A younger colleague may choose his own road, while Chanda may remain to examine her accounts. Here the author does not turn home into a metaphorical reward or final refuge. Rather, the two times of departure—family choice and the settlement of wages—are prevented from becoming necessarily dependent on each other within the same character. This distinction may be compared with the title Mahaprasthanika, but no event-based derivation from the ancient royal journey is established.

Chapter 202 — Kabir's Return

The Red-Bordered Handkerchief: Material Memory and Uncertain Origins

Kabir takes a red-bordered handkerchief and three envelopes from a cupboard: a record of foster care, an unverified account of birth, and a private letter. He keeps the third envelope inside for now. From the beginning, the limits of the three subjects are distinct. His mother's memory connects the handkerchief with the day Kabir came home, but she does not know where the cloth was originally made. This fine distinction prevents the lived experience of belonging and a complete account of descent from becoming synonymous.

His mother's sorting of rice, a sparrow's nest, and the envelope kept close to Kabir produce a span of domestic time in which the question of identity does not displace daily affection. Grass carried into a new nest on an old branch is an image; making it “proof of birth” would be a metaphorical excess imposed by the reader. The novel acknowledges the emotional value of an object without using it to fill a documentary absence with an imagined history of birth.

Foster Relationships and the Story of Birth: The Art of an Empty Field

Before Ruhani and Rama Karna, separate entries are prepared for the duration of foster care, available school papers, the status of the birth source, and personal wishes. An official proposes drawing a single, simple family line for the software's convenience. Kabir refuses to accept that convenience at the cost of the complexity of his life. An elderly man waiting there fears that an empty field will expose the child to humiliation. Thus absence is not merely a technique used by the narrator: it is an exposed space liable to generate future social questions.

Kabir refuses to have the mother who raised him recorded as "temporary," but he does not obstruct verification of the birth account. His victory does not consist in discovering his ancestry; it is the right to choose the wording of two different kinds of relationship for himself. Another meeting with Subhadra remains necessary, and confirmation of the origin is still outstanding. The narrator indicates Kabir's distress without inventing a biography for the absent birth parent.

The Landing and Remittances: The Economic Time of Another Narrative Thread

From the records centre Kabir enters Shanti Bote's world at the landing. During the three-crossing trial, the merchant argues that unloading wages should be marked "included." Shanti asks who added that line, and when. Her work is named on both sides of the border, yet the woman doing both jobs is one and the same. The narrator sets the professional renaming of a worker beside the domestic question of identity, without pretending that the disputes arise from the same cause.

Amir Kulhaiya discusses remittances sent by three families. A broker promising a common code offers speed and a particular fee; a family member asks about the withdrawal route and the right to receive payment individually. Amir does not merely preach at a worker who urgently needs to send money to an ill mother. He explains the charges and risks of two authorised services. An older page headed "Fariyani" does not establish the entire remittance route, and a break in Nasima's "Mechi" travel document is a separate difficulty.

A Narrative Returning to Three Homes

Kabir meets Subhadra, repairs a loose table leg and water-damaged bricks at Sarita's school, and returns to his mother in the evening. This threefold return—to a source person, public education, and the foster home—keeps "return" from becoming only a search for biological beginnings. He does not claim ownership of every possible answer from Subhadra; he offers dependable labour through his presence at Sarita's school, without

imposing an involuntary distance from his mother. Each scene has the time of a different social relationship.

His mother admits her curiosity about the woman who gave birth to him; Kabir does not turn the question into an accusation. A spoonful of khichdi, a final request to bring salt from the market, and the sight of the red handkerchief establish continuity through domestic actions. Their sequence does not bring the principal internal story to an end. Instead, it shows how a living conversation between mother and son can continue throughout an ordinary day even when the sentence about birth remains incomplete.

Naira's Sealed Envelope, Funds in Transit, and the Reader's Resistance

Kabir does not open the envelope marked “private—not sent”; Naira's phone remains in joint custody. The handkerchief, the private letter, and the public archive offer three different entrances into narrative. At the next dawn, the three remittances are entered separately: the first family's money has arrived, the second remains in transit, and the third needs its instructions checked again. This prevents an unwarranted claim of completeness between the opening report of the travelling group and the domestic “return.”

The chapter's distinctive achievement is that it does not reduce the tenderness of living relationships to a mere supplement to legal proof of belonging. Yet its characters continually speak the mature language of documentary categories, independence, and privacy, so that awkward silences and spontaneous mistakes can seem scarce. The elderly man's opposition, the broker's impatience, the mother's question about an unseen birth parent, and a child's gathering stones introduce important contrary voices into this didactic uniformity.

The Kitchen Clock and the Gap in Birth Knowledge: Two Incommensurable Measures of Time

Kabir's curiosity about his birth is central, but Subhadra's wet rice, the fixed hour for medicine, and the night's khichdi place that curiosity inside domestic time. His mother's “eat breakfast first” is no pointless pause that relieves dramatic tension; it makes room for the body's recurring needs amid memory and inquiry. The sparrow building a new nest on an old branch provides a counter-image to foster care, but the text does not claim that the handkerchief's first weaver or the first house of birth has thereby become known.

At Ruhani's table, an official who sees the blank space for "family of origin" suggests connecting the two households with a single line. The simple diagram would offer aesthetic ease to a reader, but would erase the distinction between an unverified story of birth and documented years of upbringing. Kabir's objection is not merely factual correction. It marks the narrative inequality between two kinds of time in his life: the long, repeated labour of raising him and the uncertain, singular occurrence of birth. The new copy makes this disparity visible; it is not a complete legal solution. The elderly man's objection prevents the arrangement from becoming entirely uncontested.

The Intervals at the Landing, a Return to Work, and Private Silence

Between these domestic scenes come Shanti's unloading wages, Amir's remittances, and Nasima's travel document in its sewn binding. One person's name repeated on either side despite distinct jobs, the convenience of a shared code, and the risk that money will not arrive—these small parallel narratives take readers beyond the subject of the family line. An emigrant youth chooses an option immediately, the second family waits, and the third authorises a different recipient. Because the results differ, "freedom of decision" is not a uniform seal of a successful life but a choice made within different necessities.

On returning home, Kabir notices a loose table leg at the school and offers only an estimate of the cost of repair. Rather than building to the dramatic climax of a search for birth, the scene rests on split wood and the possibility that a child might stumble. Sarita is linked to Naira's memory, but does not transform her dead daughter's private words into another public narrative. At night Kabir's notebook protects the names of different households and unverified questions; the simplified ending "now the family has been found" is absent. Through this lowering of dramatic intensity, the novel can make its character more than a spokesman for arguments about justice: a person living with the burden of work.

Chapter 203 — A Living Companion

A Sip of Water in the Snow and a Shared Awareness of Bodily Limits

After Bhima's death, Yudhishthira is alone on a deserted, snowbound path, except for a dog. The gleam of one remaining sip of water in his vessel and an injured paw establish a bodily emergency before the scene can become an abstract moral examination. The dog first bares its teeth; Yudhishthira withdraws his hand and waits. The creature itself extends its paw, and only then is the bandage tied. This brief delay is not a proclamation of "compassion," but a practical way of dealing with a frightened being.

The stakes change when Indra's chariot appears with an invitation to heaven. Yudhishthira could not bring his brothers back, but whether to abandon his living companion now is still a matter of his choice. Indra's argument centres on the alleged inconsistency between leaving the dead brothers behind and forgoing an opportunity for the dog's sake; Yudhishthira distinguishes the circumstances of the two events. The narrator does not turn this disagreement into a solitary discourse of wisdom. Cold, exhaustion, and the waiting injured creature beside them preserve the scene's dramatic pressure.

In the fifth textual segment, an injured brown dog appears outside the shelter in Videhapur in 2042. Repair of the roof, an alleged five-day period, veterinary examination, and a neighbour's concern for children's safety provide the scene with practical foundations. The ancient dog will be revealed as Dharma incarnate; the modern dog undergoes no such final metamorphosis. The two strands are not merely interchangeable metaphors for responses to suffering. Each is a narrative with its own facts, and preserving this difference is essential.

Ruhani steps forward to hear the neighbour's fear for her child, identifies a safe distance along the veranda, and separates the costs of treatment and repair. Javed's ledger records the income he has lost by giving up performances with animals; the purchase of cotton for bandages from Meera Banjara raises the distinction between a donation and a fair price. Here the claim of companionship with an animal does not permit anyone else's labour to become unpaid. The rain mat, the smell of medicine, and the continuing dampness of the floor covering supply the scene's sensory continuity.

Binu Darai's Two Accounts: The Narrative Relationship Between Affection and Income

Binu Darai receives news that household expenditure and her individual savings are to be recorded separately in the family's remittance, although the money has not yet arrived. Her mother-in-law fears that two accounts will mean two kitchens. Binu divides rice between two plates and then returns it to a single storage vessel. This small domestic action refuses to treat her right to speak about her own income and her wish to remain part of the household as mutually exclusive.

“Sir” is a place-indication on an old letter, on the basis of which her brother-in-law wants a simple line drawn across a travel document. Binu refuses an anonymous interpretation of the letters; Amir asks for independent confirmation. The service centre receives instructions, but actual receipt of the money is still unconfirmed. Binu's new account book becomes a subplot about plural relationships. Before assimilating it to

compassion for the dog, its independent economic narrative must be recognised.

The Supain Cart, Cotton, and an Unsettled Price

The old customer ledger belonging to Meera and her sister's cart bears the word “Supain.” It preserves a limited memory of which customer received how many consignments, not an entire map of waterways. A prospective business partner offers to combine the jobs under a single rate; the sister demands verification of the claims made by her longstanding customers. When the shelter needs clean cotton, the question is how to purchase the sister's goods, not how to take the whole stock free of charge in the name of help.

Later, a separate haulage arrangement is settled for one day; the partnership rate for the second day awaits examination of its rate sheet. This small subplot slows the chapter's overall movement, but preserves the concrete rights of petty trade beside the large moral proclamation about kindness to animals. Readers learn that consent varies with persons and goods: “companionship” is not a synonym for collective ownership.

Dharma's Transformation and the Unresolved Treatment in the Modern Story

The ancient dog is revealed in the form of Dharma and the test is concluded. The modern dog reaches a veterinarian, but full recovery is not guaranteed; temporary accommodation and the repair arrangement remain under trial. This is the fundamental structural asymmetry between the two conclusions. Epic compassion receives a divine reward, whereas modern care demands uncertain labour and another appointment.

The critical risk is that the characters' careful replies often resemble an exemplary classroom lesson. Nevertheless, the wounded creature's hesitation, the neighbour's legitimate safety question, Javed's real costs, Binu's unconfirmed remittance, and the sister's customer dues survive inside the narrative without easy settlement. The distinct time of these lives prevents the great final moral scene of the Mahaprasthana from becoming indistinguishable from modern people's obligations after death and loss.

Injury, Distance, and the Animal's Wordless Presence

The Himalayan scene begins with the dog's injury, a sip of water, and Yudhishthira's action of pulling back his hand. The dog shows its teeth; the king does not seize it as a passive object to be “rescued.” The animal moves its paw of its own accord, and only then is it bandaged. This minute hesitation allows the narration to acknowledge a being unable to express

its mind in words. The reader is not thereby granted complete access to the dog's inner consciousness: its trembling, retreat, and renewed movement are observable behaviour. In this respect, the creature's narrative independence is established even before its divine identity is disclosed.

At the contemporary shelter an old dog is injured. It is placed carefully on a mat; the neighbour asks about the children's safety, and the outcome of treatment is uncertain. The dog of the ancient epic ultimately appears in the form of Dharma; the modern story claims no analogous transformation. The comparative strength of the narration lies in this explicit inequality. In the ancient journey, refusal to abandon a companion becomes a god's test; at the modern shelter, the same kind of decision becomes entangled in five days of repairs, veterinary expenses, and arrangements for night duty. The care performed without a promise of divinity is not assigned a lower narrative value.

The Characters' Limited Cooperation: Mutual Scrutiny of Compassion and Labour

Ruhani objects to arbitrarily deducting the cost of the dog's medicine from Javed's wages; Javed offers service during the first watch; Kabir states the limits of his weekly time; and Binu agrees to assist for half an hour. Collective care grows out of these distinct commitments. No one promises limitless sacrifice, and this restraint is itself a moral achievement of the narrative. The neighbour's fear of being bitten is not presented as a villain's stupidity: the safety of the children in the lane and that of the animal are both genuine external conditions of the story.

Meera Banjara's sister does not construct an objective geography of routes from her business notebook bearing “Supain”; she preserves the memory of customers and earnings. Cotton is bought at an appropriate price for Ruhani's shelter; the entire cart is not converted into a donation. At Binu's home a decision is made to list common expenses and personal savings separately, but the receipt of funds has yet to be confirmed. These two parallel stories of livelihood give workers autonomy around the centre of compassion. The injured animal's story does not erase the value of everyone's work by becoming a festival of sentimental display.

Chapter 204 — Not a Mountain but a Doorway

The Swollen Door and the Incompleteness of Return

At dawn the open school door sticks because of the rainwater. A girl folds a piece of notebook cardboard and slips it beneath it; Sarita insists that the frame be repaired first. Against the next stage of the distant, snowbound Mahaprasthana, the title “Not a Mountain but a Doorway” makes this

ordinary repair the central narrative event. The reader's attention shifts from "how was the height crossed?" to "how is the right to enter created?"

Kabir notices new nails in the old desk; the experiences of those returning from the journey have been placed in a box of papers, but a local child asks whether they will listen to a story first or start counting. Sarita names Naira's death and Urmila's unpaid dues, but does not grant the school an automatic right to become a memorial either to her dead daughter or to the institution. Preparations for an evening event of annual public reading, open accounts, and song create recurring public time rather than a single day's final closure.

Documents from the Return Journey and the Independent Movement of the Cart

Meera Banjara's sister has delivered four sacks, but the fourth receipt was initially missing. Sonmati Turi's bamboo and Niru Kumal's clay products retain separate risks of breakage even under a joint trading arrangement. A manager's line declaring "the collective decision is final" introduces the danger of a new monopoly within cooperation. Meera demands an amendment: the owner of each consignment must be able to verify the damage to it.

The sister agrees to try the partnership for one day, not to surrender the whole business. Even when the fourth customer's slip is received by phone, payment does not arrive immediately. The sequence depends on a concrete distinction between events: goods delivered, some acknowledgment received, money outstanding. It would be difficult to open the entire story by treating "Supain" as a marvellous literary key to geography. On the available page, it is a limited sign from customer records.

Public Reading and the Decision Not to Disclose a Story

In Padma's travel document, the source of each account and permission for publication are marked separately. While reading aloud, she deliberately omits certain pages. A listener asks how an incomplete reading can be called a complete story. Padma explains that she has not obtained the source person's consent. What emerges is not an all-knowing narrator but the limits of a living participant's decision about what may be read. This is also an independent aesthetic question: a blank page increases curiosity, but does not automatically authorise its fulfilment.

A proposal had been made to write "all achievements" of the journey into the final report in order to obtain a grant. Sarita insists that work still outstanding must be recorded as outstanding. The open accounts keep Gomati's Urāhi wages, Shanti's unloading work, Amir's remittance options, and Binu's funds not yet received in distinct categories. A proposal

for a colourful publicity booklet seeks to make the anonymous storyteller and traces of Naira's private memory into inspirational headlines. The scene tests the political and narrative desire to write a conclusion.

An Interval of Snow and the Modern Transfer of Authority

In the fifteenth textual segment the story briefly returns to Yudhishthira among the snow, Indra's chariot, and the companion animal revealed as Dharma. The divine resolution of the ancient final ascent is not a previous event causing the modern school's transfer of authority. Then Javed's animal-free shadow performance, the injured dog's rest, and the children's questions restore the modern sequence of scenes. The cut invites comparison without effacing the autonomous times of the two narratives.

A proposal is made for Sanket to keep the committee's key for three months. He recognises the autonomy of the local girls' and boys' labour. A girl refuses committee duty because of her examinations; Sarita recognises both acceptance and refusal as rights. The two signatures recording transfer of the key, together with public copies available for reading by subject, bring this event to completion. But the new committee's long-term capacity, the question of its name, and outstanding payments remain matters for testing.

The Incomplete Assembly of an Artistic Ending

The young people disagree over three names for the annual event's signboard: “Open Doorway,” “Open School,” and “Courtyard of Questions.” No final voting result is given. An elderly woman, tired of seeing the empty field where Urmila's dues should be, asks how many days it will remain empty. Sarita fixes a time on the following day to compare the original wage slip. The question demands accountability in time, not an ending that declares “absence is ethical.”

The final image—door half-open, children's drawing of a doorway, signatures for the transfer of keys, and no separate celebratory feast—stands in clear contrast to the grand vision of climbing a mountain. Its artistic achievement lies in locating the beauty of a community institution's birth in the repair of an object. Its limitation is that Padma, Tara, and Sarita find procedurally correct answers to most disputes with remarkable speed. The disagreement over the event's name and the impatience of Urmila's family become necessary resistance to this well-organised flow.

The Event of the Key: Not Closure but a New Institutional Narrative

The stuck door at dawn and the worn frame take readers far from the novel's first kitchen, confronting them with the daily life of a communal

space. Work on the doorway resists the temptation to close the story with "the group has departed." The transfer of the key is an event marked by signatures, but receiving a key, meeting regular expenses, and earning public confidence belong to three different time frames. The half-open door in the thirty-first textual segment is thus more than an elevated symbol. It is also a practical consequence: it remains open to let the smell of paint escape.

When girls and local artisans assume central roles in the new committee, the authority of Tara or Sarita does not disappear; its use changes. A new decision is not deemed automatically legitimate until it has been read, questioned, and connected to actual costs. Readers see the everyday making of an institution: repairing an incorrectly driven nail, listing objects, separating heads of payment, finding time to return home, and providing paper on which objections can be made. To call the change in this small programme a historical "revolution" would distort the scale of the novel. "An incomplete transfer" is a more accurate final description here.

When an elderly woman from Urmila's family looks at the empty space for a name, she is not simply demanding the name of her choice. She asks how long a worker's presence will remain incompletely recorded. Sarita keeps two questions distinct: public commemoration of the person by name and the unfinished payment owed to her. In place of oral reassurance, the narrative result is a date on which the original slip will be examined. The story preserves the family's question before transforming Urmila into a passive epithet on a memorial.

The layered final scene—preparations to leave, a shared meal, the smell of paint, children's drawing of a door, the artisans' list of tools, and paperwork—dissolves the interim conclusion of Mahaprasthanika Parva into ordinary labour. Compared with the discipline of announcing "the story is over," it is an extended delay in the scene: workers enter the next phase of their lives, but readers are left holding a list of unfinished tasks. In this movement, the descent from the epic's towering ascent to a modern doorway is not a loss of elevation but a change of focalisation.

Svargarohana Parva / Uttara Kanda

Chapter 205 — The Register of Heaven

The Brass Plaque and the Choice of Names

The chapter opens with a misplaced blow of a hammer. A teenager is about to drive a nail into a brass nameplate when Sarita tells him to read the

name first: a name once engraved is hard to alter. The first proposed list gives the institution's office-bearers handsome lettering but makes no mention of night transport, the lifting of wet bedding, or cleaning work. The novel thus makes the politics of remembrance a question not of abstract ideas but of the plaque's dimensions, the height of its letters, and the space available. A young woman on the new committee preserves both original proposed lists; she will not conceal how the differences arose.

Urmila's sister asks where the actual washing, night duty, and unpaid transport charges will appear beside the word “martyr” in the clothing register. Gomati reads three colours in the ledger—work performed, partial receipt, and disputed additional items—but her reading does not establish the cause of death. Padma records “verified particulars of life and work” separately from “the present status of claims and inquiries.” The result is a story of still-living economic obligations rather than a merely symbolic tribute to the dead.

The Return of Budhan's Name: Uncertainty in the List

Seeing “Budhan Das” in the list, Shashibhushan Mahapatra recalls the hospital's first confusion: whether a body belonged to Budhan Das or Budhan Sah had not then been fully established. His earlier refusal to put a guessed name on a receipt for clothing now returns as a causal element in the plot, brought into action by a new object, the brass plaque. Rama distinguishes three questions: medical notification of a death, individual identification of the body, and consent to public naming. The return of the old dispute does not create a false appearance of settlement.

The teenager asks whether a person becomes alive again if the name is left off the plaque. His question brings together the pain of being forgotten and the harm caused by misidentification. It is decided that an unverified personal name will not be engraved on the permanent plaque; an inquiry reference number will remain in a public progress register, with the family's private materials protected. The earlier misprinted page is not destroyed: the history of revision is preserved. The narrator makes the process of correction an outcome of the plot but does not invent a definitive identity for the deceased.

The Ancient Register of Heaven: Concrete Limits of the Two Temporal Narratives

In the eleventh and twelfth textual segments comes an ancient scene of the ascent to heaven. Yudhishthira sees Duryodhana occupying a place of honour in the divine realm, but cannot find his brothers or Draupadi. Within the epic plot, the difference between the ordering of honour and the absence of loved ones generates his question. A conceptual resemblance

to names on the modern memorial may be observed, but Duryodhana's seat is not an entry in a municipal administrative register; the ancient moral crisis belongs to its own story-world.

A central point common to both periods is resistance to the claim that "the list is complete, so there can be no questions." Yudhishthira wants an answer about his absent loved ones; Urmila's sister wants an answer about the dead worker's actual labour and unpaid wages. But scientific or administrative verification of a dead person's identity differs from the narrative reality of heavenly light. Padma's public reading does not turn the ancient story into exact evidence for the modern archive. The artistic validity of editing across two times depends on keeping this difference intact.

The Living Worker's Pay, Grief, and Privacy

Uma says that she is alive and wants her daily wages, not a place on a list of the dead. Sonmati asks for the cost of the bamboo memorial frame and payment for her time. A man claims to speak on behalf of a sanitation worker; Kamala asks whose consent he has obtained. The new committee's writer seeks separate individual permission to publish verified names. These voices do not dissolve into a single collective category called "helpers": each changes the rules of recording.

Urmila's sister makes publication conditional on excluding private illness and dramatisations of the final moments. Kabir and Sarita prevent statements on Naira's private phone from being turned into inspirational pronouncements; motherhood does not confer ownership of every private utterance. Niraj Panda and Shashibhushan distinguish artisans' charges, family assistance, and payment for voluntary mourning rites. The old travel name "Ganga" does not prove that every dead person's body was transported along that route. These threads set out multiple limits on the right to narrate grief.

The Revised Plaque's Internal Incompleteness

The final arrangement has three levels: names with verified death identities and consent to publication; a separate account of the work performed by living and deceased workers; and a protected register of disputed identities and sums under inquiry. The office-bearers' funding credit goes on a different board. On the first brass plaque, the purpose of the memorial and the next review date are engraved instead of names. This movement from mechanical finality to a revisable public story is a genuine event in the narrative.

Yet Urmila's remaining night-duty wages are not paid today; only the hearing date is fixed. Budhan's identification remains inadequate, and

Naira's absence cannot be overcome. Kabir's fleeting fancy that Naira might have read her name meets a distinct, real grief in Sarita's reply. Without this subtle pain and the human pause of a shared plate of khichdi, the chapter might have resembled a report from a model memorial committee. Despite the risk of uniformly instructive speech, the incomplete outcomes resist an artificially happy ending.

The Rigidity of Engraved Letters and the Revisability of Paper

The hammer's missed blow against the brass plaque is a meaningful accident: the formal grandeur of remembrance begins with the ordinary resistance of material. A name once engraved on stone is difficult to change, while a family's statement, a medical account of death, and the form of permission to publish may differ. Rama sets three blank sheets on the table, while Shashibhushan recalls the uncertain name "Budhan" on an earlier receipt for materials. The scene makes the real risk of a mistaken memory becoming permanent tangible within the story. The name is withheld, but no person's death is denied.

At the end, the first plaque carries the memorial's purpose and a review date instead of the hierarchy of office-bearers; a separate plate of verified names will be installed with the families' permission. This change of arrangement changes the meaning within the narrative form itself. Rather than one fixed "final list," the date of correction, open questions, and protected, closed pages together constitute a layered memory. Urmila's family receives a hearing time, not the full amount due. The gleaming metal cannot serve to make them forget that incompleteness.

Focalisation in the Heavenly Scene: The Meaning of Presence

In the ancient section Yudhishthira sees Duryodhana's heavenly honour, but the absence of his brothers and Draupadi remains at the centre of his experience. The narrator does not claim that Yudhishthira's viewpoint comprehends the entire system of justice in the realm of the gods. Readers remain within his astonishment and questioning. The distance between a visible register and remembered presence may resonate with the modern dispute over names on a plaque, but the mythic account of heaven cannot be emptied into a mere metaphor for office records. The ancient strand occupies a distinct level, with its religious imagination and the character's shock.

When Uma and Kamala raise questions about the workers' register, the proposal to combine living and dead workers in a single list is withdrawn. If Urmila's title of "martyr" hides the washing, night duty, and lifting of goods that she performed, the memorial narrative will lose most of the time of her life. The objection to extracting phrases from Naira's private

phone and issuing a new “message” in her name belongs to the same problem. Public presentation of grief and the rights of a private mind are not the same; the source character's unanswered silence resists the public manufacture of a symbol.

Chapter 206 — Uttara and Parikshit

What Now for Those Who Live? The Place of a Question

After the memorial list is corrected in the previous chapter, a girl writes, “What now for those who are alive?” The nail holding the new sheet is loose; Ruhani sets safe limits on the height at which a child may help. This small opening scene moves beyond commemoration of the dead to confront concern for the living. A child frightened by the hammer's sound, a notebook soaked in water, and different situations of reluctant speech cannot all be turned into one specimen of the traumatised child's mind.

Sarita rejects the proposal to exhibit the names and photographs of children in crisis to donors. Ruhani lays out separate mats for play and drawing: some may be present through words, some through colour, others through silence. A teacher wants immediate “practice in speaking of suffering,” while Ruhani questions the obligation to tell every story today. Focalisation respects the child's own time instead of becoming the hero's speech of rescue.

Close Focalisation on Uttara: An Infant's Breath against the Future of a Dynasty

In textual segments seven to twelve of the ancient time, the epic story of Abhimanyu's death and Parikshit's survival is reread through Uttara's bodily fear. After the episode of saving the womb threatened by the Brahmastra, Uttara puts a palm near the infant's nose to feel his breathing. Courtiers call him “the surviving lamp of the Kuru line”; Uttara wants to keep the baby warm, limit the crowd of onlookers, and protect the time he needs for sleep. The close scene of present motherhood transforms the ancient figure of dynastic preservation into uncertain living time.

Subhadra refuses to let heroic Abhimanyu become merely a dead emblem of battle; she remembers his childhood hunger, games, and dust. When the older Parikshit asks, after breaking a clay bow, whether it is his responsibility to repair everything, Uttara answers that he should mend as much as he can, without gathering everyone's sorrow into one hand. In later ancient scenes, segments twenty-five and twenty-six, a guard's trembling hand and request to rest teach the prince to hear another

person's "not now." This ancient episode is not the direct lived experience of the modern child, but a question in another narrative time.

Children's Safety: From Budget Categories to a Physical Route

A child at the shelter coughs; Rukhsana moves the child away from dust and has the wood-sanding carried outside. An employee suggests recording the cause of illness on the form for convenience, but she records only observed dust and leaves medical causation to a physician's examination. A mother wants to know the clear route of safe exit next time. An abandoned bench is removed, a date for temporary paving is fixed, and funding for permanent repairs remains undecided. These actions turn child safety from a sentiment into a spatial and structural narrative question.

The school's two boards separate information for visitors from personal privacy: one publicly lists safe drinking water, exits, and care hours; the other carries questions children choose voluntarily to offer. A girl wants to display her drawing of a painted doorway, not a photograph of her face. Not every story of fear is suitable for publication. Yet the characters describe these procedures in unusually precise language; the literary risk is that the disordered experience of an individual's suffering will be compressed into an ideal set of instructions.

Voluntary Devotion, New Labour, and Urmila's Separate Arrears

Niraj Panda accepts a family's voluntary decision to hold a rite for a surviving child, but refuses to turn it into donor-directed spending from the common relief account. Devotion, payment for services, and assistance with food and shelter are three different matters. One elderly woman asks that devotion not be insulted; another family decides not to participate in the rite. Both families continue to draw water from the same tap. This small simultaneity of action forms an artistic basis for coexistence.

Urmila's sister asks who will now wash the new children's clothes. Gomati prepares a schedule for new laundry and childcare. When a member calls it "natural household work," a woman points out the hours she would have to give up at her shop. The novel does not turn that sacrifice into estimated earnings without verification; it asks for a fixed rate for the actual work. The unpaid dues from before Urmila's death remain separate from the new labour being undertaken today. Without that distinction, memory of the dead would rest on another woman's unpaid work.

The Clay Horse, a Repeated Question, and an Incomplete Tomorrow

A child's clay horse breaks; Javed offers repair or the possibility of imaginative play. The child's laughter grants a temporary respite from fear,

not absolution for social damage. Kabir does not open Naira's private unsent letter; he does not want to attach the dead person's absence to a child's story. Sarita likewise refrains from making the painted doorway a symbol of her daughter's death. These scenes allow the narrator to preserve an interval between adult bereavement and a child's different life.

A young person finally asks, “In place of whose mistake must the survivors go on living?” Padma does not answer, but keeps the question for the next lesson. This indeterminacy is artistic: ancient Parikshit's future cannot be reduced to the reproduction of a dynasty, and the modern child cannot be made to carry all the debts of an earlier disaster. By the day's end a safe route has opened, but regular funding remains incomplete and fear in the shelter has not wholly disappeared. Instead of grief the narrative offers the possibility of play, not a proclamation of certain liberation.

The Infant's Breath and the Burden of the Future: Uttara's Inner Movement

Amid memories of Abhimanyu's death and the Brahmastra, Uttara places her fingers near the child's nose and feels him breathe. Parikshit's status as guardian of the desired line is announced from the outset, but the mother's immediate questions concern clothing, sleep, hunger, and fear. The political time of the epic and the minute time of childbirth do not advance at the same speed. Subhadra resists remembering Abhimanyu solely as a “symbol of heroism”: to forget the living boy's hunger and running about would erase his life even before his death. The narrator does not leave this emotional argument as a sermon detached from Uttara's bodily experience.

When Parikshit's little bow breaks, Uttara does not answer his question, “If I become king, must I put everything right?” with an impossible promise of universal repair. The leap in time from infant to playing child conveys the future of the tradition without giving the dramatic completeness of an entire biography. Parikshit, who sees a soldier's shaking hand, is taught first to ask the soldier what he needs; the man wants rest. Before the identity of kingship, this small scene of hearing “not now” constructs the character as a human being.

Children's Questions, Noticeboards, and the Right to Control What Is Seen

At the contemporary school a child's coughing because of dust, the refusal to speculate about its medical cause, and the removal of a bench to open a safe exit bring the question of survivors' futures into the bodily risks of the present. Permanent repair of the paved passage has not been approved; calling the temporary opening of a safe route a permanent infrastructure

improvement would be unfounded. A mother does not demand that all fear end. She wants to know where the exit will be if dust rises again. The narration presents a practical reorganisation of circumstances rather than a denial of feeling.

The girl wants to put her drawing of the painted doorway on the public board, not her photograph. The story thus separates the child's presence as witness from the right to publish her image. When a small clay horse breaks, Javed gives it the form of a play; laughter is brief, not an order to wipe the child's hurt from the mind. Sarita does not project her grief over Naira onto the child's drawing. The child's picture, a repeated question, and rice boiling at night show a community willing to receive questions instead of arriving at the facile conclusion that "the future is bright."

Chapter 207 — Janamejaya's Question

An Unexpected Laugh and an Uncertain Sound Entering the Story

A woman's laugh suddenly comes from the audio device on the open school's table; the button settings are unclear because of an old, incomplete programme list. The story begins with an unstable sound whose actual source still needs checking. The young person's earlier question, "In place of whose mistake must the survivors go on living?" remains on the board. The opening tension among recorded sound, an unnamed voice, and a question makes narrative reliability and the listener's rights into dramatic objects.

Rashid Bhat's notebook distinguishes in different colours four lines taught by his grandmother and three he composed himself after a small bridge collapsed. Dev Gayin protects the broken string of his sarangi, while his niece Ragini questions her right to perform. Some oral lines are added, but their authorship should not be dissolved under the name of a single ancient folk song. The family transmission of sound and an artist's new creation do not belong to an identical timeline within the story.

Janamejaya's Court: The Expansion of Grief into Vengeance

The sixth textual segment brings the royal court of Hastinapura after Parikshit's death. Janamejaya hears of his father's death from Takshaka's bite; private grief for days spent with his father takes up the public language of state vengeance. An elder's question—how far will punishment extend?—is not a ready-made political or religious maxim but an anticipation of the risks of the king's decision. At the proposal for the sacrifice, the narrative places dissenting testimony alongside the king's fury.

The course of the story extends to the beginning of the sacrifice, serpents falling into the fire, the attempt to draw Takshaka into it, and Astika's arrival. Astika asks as a boon that the sacrifice be stopped. Janamejaya halts the violence, but the creatures already cast into the flames do not return. The importance of this ending is not the divine happy resolution "justice is complete." It is the simultaneous recognition that a destructive process can be halted and that destruction already accomplished is irreversible. The character's ethical decision takes place amid the inevitable losses of what has happened.

The Young Listener's Interruption and Cuts between Two Times

A teenage girl at the modern school asks whether killing all the serpents would bring the king's father back. A young man endorses the king's rhetoric of revenge; Padma stops the reading to write down the question. The ancient sacrifice is repeatedly cut against the modern classroom, yet the school listeners do not become eyewitnesses inside Janamejaya's royal court. They hear the story and question it. The levels of listening and of narrated events remain separate.

During this listening, Kabir silently remembers Naira's phone and her unsent letter. He does not attempt to disclose the dead person's final secret to answer the question. A creative contrast arises between epic revenge and his private mourning, but Kabir is neither Janamejaya's moral representative nor his direct equivalent. The girl's later question—may a person whose story is being heard interrupt and ask questions?—opens the chapter's next dispute about the act of narration.

The Price of Song: The Material Livelihood behind Storytelling

Rashid has separate unpaid fees for a performance last Phagun and for its accompanist. A new programme organiser is eager to put a new reading online, complete with the old voice. Rashid wants an official receipt from the event, not cash offered as a private favour. Dev sets separate permissions for a single performance, a school listening, and public rebroadcast. This intrusion of livelihood reveals the real price behind attractive speeches about the epic tradition of oral transmission.

If the credits for the four old lines and three new ones are merged, someone's creative labour will disappear. After the performance, receipt of two payments is documented, and a rate for reuse has been written in advance; nevertheless, a full accounting of earlier improper use remains outstanding. One announcement that "folk culture has been saved" cannot complete the economic sequence of the stage. The dust of the collapsed bridge lives in Rashid's voice alongside literary invention and personal memory.

Editing Sound, the Right to Listen, and Its Limits

The performers listen to the first copy of the new recording; at one point a mobile notification tone has intruded into Dev's playing. This small technical incident links the broad history of an earlier tradition to the rules for editing a present-day sound file, though calling it merely a technical fix would be insufficient. The sound of the song, the performer's identity, the fee, and the future of permission do not settle into one undifferentiated form within a single file.

In the Rashid–Dev–Chetan episode, three levels emerge: the source of the story, oral additions, and its economy. One limitation is that Padma and the principal characters often advance perfectly balanced arguments, making the modern debate appear over-organised beside the king's violent impulse. Yet the interruption by the young listeners, the unexpected sound in the recording, the performers' unpaid old fees, and the irreversibility of the king's violence disrupt that orderly pattern.

Embedded Narrative, Pause, and the Listener's Counterquestion

In the ancient story of Janamejaya's serpent sacrifice, grief arising from a father's death becomes indiscriminate punishment by fire. Padma's reading at school does not bring the historical moment directly to life again; it is a story retold in the time of present listeners. When a girl asks whether killing all serpents will restore the king's father, the reading stops midway. Here interruption is not a failure to listen but the listener's new power over how the subject is narrated. Astika's halting of the sacrifice is a subsequent change, not an imaginary means of restoring the serpents already killed.

The two levels of narrative structure must be kept distinct. Janamejaya's grief and commands are events in the ancient story-world; Padma's contemporary reading, children's questions, and the editing of recordings are modern events. The reader does not witness the same event "occurring again" in two ages, but experiences a changing reception through retelling. Rashid's familial laughter, heard unexpectedly, is also the uninvited entrance of a third voice at this narrative level. Epic revenge and permission to broadcast today are not the same injustice, although in each a differently formed question arises: "Whose decision applies to whom?"

The Song's Seven Lines: The Labour Structure of Inheritance and Originality

In Rashid's notebook, four lines inherited from his grandmother and three composed after the bridge collapsed are written in different inks. The detail resists reducing the song to a limitless, anonymous "folk voice." The old melody, new experience, a musician's sarangi, and a circulating clipped

extract on a phone constitute four separate sources of editing. Rashid receives a receipt for today's work, but his fee from Phagun remains unpaid; correctly recording a poor artist's name is no substitute for remuneration. The text exposes the economic relations through which a beautiful sound is made.

In the evening, the edited audio is played again for the performers, and Rashid, Dev, and Sanket identify different discrepancies. An old phone's notification tone was mixed in at one point; Dev refuses to count it as part of his performance today. Four uses receive separate permissions: listening in the school, replay for study, public dissemination, and advertising. This technical division is also a matter of form: the apparent unity of a recording is manufactured by editing, while the voices and strings within it are individual labour. The chapter leaves the source of an earlier unauthorised broadcast uncertain to the end. Its achievement is therefore only the cautious beginning of a new dissemination.

Chapter 208 — Listeners of Ugrashrava

Stained Pages: Distinct Narratives of Genealogical Song and History

Two pages of Chetan Bhatak's manuscript carry yellow stains of clarified butter and blue ink that has spread. One page records a genealogical line sung at an ancient ritual; the other is a copy of a much later invitation. In performance Chetan had built a genealogical staircase across the gap between those two points. His admission is not a public moral defeat but a difficult encounter between a voice earned through livelihood and the need to correct himself. The material layers of the manuscript expose a false joining of narrative threads.

A household representative fears that the honour of his ancestors will decline. Chetan proposes not to remove the song but to withdraw the certain genealogical claim attached to its performance. An elderly woman respects her grandmother's memory without turning the folk song into the official seal of history. This dispute exposes not a simple opposition of “memory versus history” but the social cost of recklessly declaring something to be established history.

The Reading at Naimisharanya: The Listener Changes the Narrator's Authority

The fifth textual segment moves to Naimisharanya during Shaunaka's long sacrifice. Ugrashrava Sauti sets out the tradition inherited from his father Lomaharshana and the chain by which he heard Vaishampayana's account at Janamejaya's serpent sacrifice. This layered oral system is a clear frame of narration: Vaishampayana's earlier recitation, Ugrashrava's

recollection, Shaunaka's assembly, and the reader of the present text occupy different spatial and narrational levels of the same story. Ugrashrava himself distinguishes what he heard from what he does not know.

An attendant would allow only the ascetics to ask questions. In the presence of a woman who brings water and a young man who gathers wood, Shaunaka raises the issue of access to the recitation. Ugrashrava moves his seat to make space for questions. The woman asks about unnamed labourers absent from the story of the royal house. This is not simply a modern slogan about "everyone's democratic rights" imposed on an ancient setting: it actively reconstructs the narrative frame by deciding whose hearing and questioning may enter the account.

The Incomplete Memory of the Serpent Sacrifice and the Entrance of Another Source

In answer to Shaunaka, Ugrashrava relates the chain from Parikshit's death to Janamejaya's sacrifice and the violence stopped by Astika. The young man asks what story remains for the creatures already killed. The narrator is clear: the sacrifice was stopped, but the dead did not return. The distinction between ending an event and recovering life establishes a narrative dialogue with the preceding chapter's moral movement.

A listener from another lineage brings a different recollection; the attendant worries that the sequence will break. Ugrashrava agrees to mention the conflicting source and takes responsibility for recovering the thread of his account. In Shaunaka's forest, the water-bearing woman asks why the daily work of fields after the war is absent. The reciter refuses to sell what he has not heard under his father's name. Through this disputatious repetition, the centre of narrative authority gradually shifts from the reciter to the participation of listeners.

Sajid's Camera: A New Medium of Narrative Rights

In contemporary Videhapur, Sajid Nat presents a short passage from a shadow play performed by new adult artists. Three years earlier a clipped school video had spread a false accusation of child abduction, but the new performance does not reuse that footage. The bamboo frame, cloth screen, and puppet of an elderly elephant are important: no live animal is displayed. Sajid distinguishes ownership of the original recording, credit for the performers, and the conditions of reuse.

The income is specified with unusual concreteness: from a programme receipt of ₹1,200, ₹200 of verified expenses is deducted; the remaining ₹1,000 is divided into ₹500 for Sajid, ₹300 for the two actors—₹150 each—and ₹200 for the person working the frame. If the funds do not arrive,

there is to be no unilateral deduction. In the evening, receipt of ₹1,200 and the performers' acknowledgment of payment are written down. A summary saying that "artists are given a voice" would erase this material arrangement of labour.

Durga's Song, Chetan's Correction, and an Unfinished Dispute

Durga Danuwar's song notebook contains the name "Lakhnadei." An older annotation differentiates a folk name, a poetic expression, and a measured location. Durga accepts credit for her singing but refuses to declare an exact geographical measure merely because the name appears. This independent subplot shows that, just as an oral link in a genealogy does not establish a complete descent, the sound of a folk song does not automatically establish the final truth about a place. The independent value of listening to poetry is preserved.

Chetan himself issues the slip withdrawing the mistaken genealogical claim; permission to use the family's original private material remains a separate question. He postpones the next performance so that the family can read the revised copy first. A middle-aged man is not yet satisfied, and uncertainty about Chetan's future income remains. Sajid's first fairly paid performance does not fully compensate for the damage of the earlier viral accusation. These incompletions prevent an excessively optimistic final scene of correction.

A Child's Chariot, the Ramayana to Come, and an Interim Conclusion

Outside the school a child wheels a wooden chariot. One child directs it, and another asks why no one consulted him. Two thin ropes tied to the bamboo make the turn dependent on both hands. Padma does not describe this game as archival proof of the ancient epic. By preserving the different evidentiary statuses of performance, play, and history, the scene brings the question of narrative authority into a child's actions.

At the end there are preparations for Lava and Kusha's recitation at Rama's court the following day. A young woman asks whether, on hearing his own story, the king will permit the speaker to be interrupted and questioned. Shaunaka's listeners, Chetan's correction of a false claim, and Sajid's camera are not the same evidence, but different sites of narrative authority. The chapter's beauty lies in refusing to bind oral tradition, paper, camera, and children's play into a single thread of truth. Listener-centred scenes gradually open the possibility of rewriting the act of narration.

Speaker, Listener, Earlier Speaker: Concentric Levels of Narration

In the Naimisharanya assembly, Ugrashrava tells Shaunaka the story of Janamejaya's sacrifice, although readers have already heard the Janamejaya episode through Padma's contemporary classroom. The sequence invites us to distinguish historical event, ancient recitation, modern retelling, and the reader's reconstruction. Ugrashrava's hereditary tradition of narrators does not become the one omniscient voice. The woman carrying water through the forest, the wood-gatherer, and listeners from other families interrupt with questions. They give the story energy without making Ugrashrava's knowledge automatically complete.

Padma's writing of two sentences on the school board is the modern equivalent of this arrangement of narrative levels: "A name occurs in a song" and "the song proves an unbroken genealogy" are different claims. Chetan's old manuscript sustains his livelihood; in correcting an error he must find the possibility of new performance. Honouring the memory of a genealogical song while publicly correcting an uncertain lineage does not turn music into dead historical "data." Here ownership of narration is not simply transferred from one person to another; it emerges as a collective process of listening constructed through the separate identity of each source.

The Frame of the Shadow Play and an Unfinished Past of Humiliation

A school video of Sajid had been cut to fabricate a false accusation of child abduction. The modern shadow play does not become instant counter-propaganda to heal that wound. Its bamboo frame, unseen faces behind the dark screen, sounds of hands, and consent of adult performers construct a new frame. Behind the visible image on the cloth stand working hands; the young man who moves the frame therefore asks to be named. A small amendment to the credit sheet reveals the collective creation of art normally concealed from audiences by the screen.

Once ₹1,200 has been received for the shadow play, an agreement distributes the remaining ₹1,000 after ₹200 of expenses. This is a limited confirmation of the performers' economic rights, not compensation for the earlier defamation. Setting down fixed sums in place of the organiser's preferred undefined percentage strengthens the reader's trust, but the narrator does not resolve every difficult dispute. In the closing scene, the right to ask questions becomes living practice in the children's chariot game. The proposed Lava–Kusha episode foreshadows another narrative level in the novel as a whole; Rama's assembly has not yet taken place.

Mahaprasthanika Parva / Uttara Kanda: Comprehensive Narratological Assessment of Chapters 193–204

The Parva's Design and the Editing of Time

The ancient Mahaprasthana of Chapters 193–195—succession through Parikshit and the successive falls of Draupadi and the brothers—is edited into the difficult return to public life in Chapters 201–204. Between them, Chapters 196–200 present separate modern scenes at the station, in the room, around a sealed phone, in an anonymous story, and among questions at the school. Chapter 203 expands the story of Yudhishthira's injured companion and Indra's chariot; Chapter 204 briefly revisits the ancient ascent between the jammed doorway at dawn and the transfer of keys at dusk. The parva is therefore structured not only by the succession of deaths, but by unequal and parallel processes of departure and return.

In the ancient strand, the revelation that the animal is Dharma completes a narrative test. The modern story offers no comparable conclusion in which the dog has certainly recovered, Binu's money has arrived, Shanti's wages have been paid, Meera's sister has received every outstanding sum, or the school has been wholly repaired. Through this asymmetry, modern social time remains incapable of being automatically brought to a close by divine time.

The Right to a Voice and the Unproven Continuity of Origins

Resistance to reducing the last days of Draupadi's life to one fault, Fakira's testimony about his own travel time, Kabir's memories of upbringing, Shanti's wages for crossings, and an unnamed storyteller's conditions of publication are not one narrative type. On one side are voices contesting a character's declaration of divine causation; on the other are the limits on publishing a living person's private recollections. By recognising this difference, the story produces separate focalisations rather than one hero's universal account.

“Gandak/Gandaki” and “Gohi” in Chapter 201, “Fariyani” and “Mechi” in Chapter 202, and “Sir” and “Supain” in Chapters 203–204 are scattered words from old archival records. To construct from them a self-evident, unbroken map of an ancient river route, a genealogy, or a modern consignment would be an inference going beyond the source text. The resistance between the novel's descriptions of place and the names appearing in records has literary significance.

Material Objects and Limited Endings

The planks, the lock, the blue bag, the red handkerchief, the injured dog's bedding, the cart's separate receipt, and the swollen door are objects capable of action. They halt time, measure work, protect private materials, or make safe entrance possible. They need to be read not merely as symbols on a page but as material means by which events are set in motion.

The "half-open doorway" at the end of Chapter 204 is both a narrative full stop and a question about what follows. The key has been transferred, but committee rules, routine expenditure, wages owed to a deceased worker, public naming, and the timing of corrections remain for the future narrative. The parva's larger critical achievement is to make visible the independent, incomplete, and recurring obligations of the living in the absence of the epic hero.

Achievements of Form and Objections

In linking the epic's final ascent with modern institutional labour, the work generally creates visual openings for comparison rather than claiming direct causation. Nevertheless, the characters repeatedly have orderly and just formulations about privacy, credit, and responsibility readily available to them. There is consequently a danger that the emotional uncertainties of their situations will turn into critical examples.

The artistic counterweight within the narrative lies in unresolved debts, different times of homecoming, the damaged table, exhausted artisans' pay, the elderly woman's "how many days empty?", and a girl's refusal of committee work. These autonomous voices continually test the central characters' exemplary method.

Svargarohana Parva / Uttara Kanda: Joint Assessment of Chapters 205–208

From the Register of Heaven to the Questioning Listener

Chapter 205 juxtaposes Yudhishthira's heavenly assembly with the choice of names for a modern memorial; Chapter 206 brings Uttara and Parikshit's living future beside the safety of contemporary children; Chapter 207 contrasts Janamejaya's revenge with the labour sustaining song in a classroom; and Chapter 208 places Ugrashrava at Naimisharanya alongside the narrative rights of present-day Chetan and Sajid. These four chapters create distinct scenes for an expanding sequence of questions: honour for the dead, obligations to survivors, the irreparable cost of violence, and who is allowed to ask questions.

The ancient strand does not unfold in one continuous time. From the ascent to heaven it moves back to Uttara's mourning, to Janamejaya's serpent sacrifice, and then to the narrative frame at Naimisharanya. This reversed ordering urges readers to attend to layers of narration rather than a simple historical line. The modern school of 2042 is no eyewitness to the ancient scenes; it occupies another level, that of listening, understanding, and objection.

The Distance between Material Records and Living Voices

The brass plaque, loose nail, clay horse, old song written in different inks, broken sarangi string, Chetan's ghee-stained manuscript, and Sajid's camera give the story material foundations. Each object has its specific function; making them all into one giant cycle of symbols would be a critical simplification.

Urmila's name is entered for remembrance, but all wages owed to her remain unpaid. A safe exit for the children is opened, but permanent repairs to the paved path remain outstanding. Rashid is properly paid for today's event, while older fees are separate. Chetan corrects the genealogical claim, but the dispute over the former dignity of the family is not wholly calmed. Sajid receives his first earnings, not full redress for an earlier false accusation. This sequence creates a plurality of narrative endings.

The Rights of Listening, Telling, and Retelling

A new achievement of Svargarohana Parva is its dramatic arrangement of listeners and reciters. A girl questions Padma mid-story; justice and vengeance speak in different voices in Janamejaya's court; unnamed workers' interests enter questions at Ugrashrava's assembly before Shaunaka; Chetan's oral history reveals the mistaken joining of two genealogical sources; performers demand credit for Sajid's adult production. Across these uneven situations, the question “Whose story?” produces a distinct crisis each time.

Ugrashrava's account of sources reveals several narrative levels: speaker, earlier speaker, listener, and present reader. In the modern strand, inherited lines of oral song and newly created lines occupy different positions in the art. At the same time, stopping Janamejaya's violence does not restore the creatures already killed, just as putting a deceased worker's name on a memorial does not immediately discharge outstanding wages. This comparison is dramatic, not literal identity.

Interim Conclusion and Remaining Limitations

Chapters 205–208 constitute only the joint assessment of the opening four chapters of Svargarohana Parva. The original novel contains 216 chapters in all; a definitive final evaluation of the whole Uttara Kanda's artistic construction would be unjustified without reading Chapters 209–216. The final Lava–Kusha question in Chapter 208 clearly anticipates the story to come. Rama's hearing has not yet taken place in this chapter.

A limitation remains here too: many characters quickly formulate effective exemplary maxims, and the classification of imagination and history is drawn with almost faultless clarity. Yet one person does not want a name published, another keeps an old wage ledger, another fears that correcting a genealogical song will reduce earnings, and another stops questions about a dead person's story. Because of these discordant life-times, the novel does not become merely an instructional manual on verifying information.

Chapter 209 — The Recitation of Lava and Kusha

The Opening Notebook: Different Temporalities of a Traditional Song and a Living Singer

Phulmati Pamariya's finger coming to rest at the corner of a song notebook, and the slack note of a harmonium, furnish the chapter's auditory entrance. Before a song is sung, the narrative raises a question about its heading: Phulmati is named in the invitation, yet the performance is labelled "old traditional." The distance between a song's age and the performer's present agency becomes a cause of events in the chapter, not merely a social observation. This scene is placed on the day after Chetan Bhat's correction of the genealogical song; the preceding dispute is not simply repeated but becomes an independent problem of living performance.

Phulmati is willing to preserve, with its context, an insulting line inherited from her mother for study, but refuses to sing it again herself. Her removal of the "old words" does not erase history: documentation, research reading and utterance on stage become three distinct acts in the narrative. The young organiser fears that "the song will be diminished"; the singer replies by asking whether "the artist is being diminished." Their dialogue brings the inert preservation of folk tradition into conflict with the active choice of a living person.

The Assembly at Ayodhya: An Embedded Narrative and the Limits of a Royal Audience

The singing of Lava and Kusha, taught by Valmiki in ancient Ayodhya, is a separate temporal layer placed after the modern programme. Incense, jewels, guards and the sound of the vina in the royal court bring the performance into a structure of public power. The princes sing not only Rama's valour but also Sita's solitude in the forest and the suffering caused by a royal decision. The king's motionless hand and the courtiers' request that the difficult lines be removed create tension in the scene; rather than pronounce a solution, the narrator lends weight to the continuing act of listening.

It would be incorrect to describe this scene as Sita's direct self-expression: she is absent from the assembly, and her life reaches it through the princes' voices and Valmiki's composed narrative. A story is being sung within another story; source, stage and audience occupy different positions. The similarity of the boys' faces does not immediately establish their lineage; Rama recognises the need to speak with Valmiki. Their refusal of gifts does not render the song worthless. It signifies distance from a transaction in which the story would be altered to secure royal pleasure.

Permission to Sing, Working Time and Ownership of Rhythm

The proposal to use Karim Dafali's old melody without permission by calling it a "people's tune" recalls the earlier refusal to employ Champa's stolen private message for electoral purposes. Karim's independent melody, Phulmati's revised words and Javed's proposed shadow-work each involve different creative rights; collaboration does not mean collective dispossession. The alternation of slow and rapid beats on the dholak, and the silences deliberately selected within the song, are dramatic pauses. To interpret them as an all-consuming metaphor for mourning would run against the character's own wishes.

The expenditure sheet fixes eight hundred rupees for Phulmati's performance, six hundred for Karim's playing and one-time use of the new tune, and a separate two hundred for rehearsal. Receipt of the advance is recorded, and a slip for the outstanding amount has been made; full payment has not been proved. This limited outcome is a major narrative restraint: preparing a paper, having money available in an account, getting it into the artist's hands and granting permission for future recording are not the same event. Instead of the ornamental conclusion "tradition was saved," the narrator provides specific facts about the term of use and the economic relationship.

Children's Play and Resistance to Equivalence Across Time

In an Ayodhya garden, the princes play with an earthen chariot, a stone river and a bridge made of twigs. After the solemn performance in court, their play supplies a pause in narrative time. Childhood aspiration outside royal scrutiny becomes visible when it is free of the dynastic use of their song. In the contemporary schoolchildren's game with bows, a girl would rather be an audience member who asks questions than take the role of Sita. The two scenes create formal resemblance, but they are neither the same historical event nor the same condition of children's rights.

The interval between river names matters too. When someone proposes equating the poetic references to "Triyuga" and "Lakshmana" with the contemporary geographical lines of "Tilyuga" or "Lakhandai," a question mark appears on the blackboard. Phulmati accepts the memory contained in local names but does not turn her song into an engineering measurement. Ancient text, modern song and contemporary site survey enter into dialogue without usurping one another's archival positions.

The Event of Public Recitation, Remaining Disagreement and Evaluation of Craft

At the evening programme the newly approved song is performed. A question is raised, the singer explains her choice, and the outstanding payment remains unsettled. The chapter's achievement is that it does not leave the singer as a passive "bearer of tradition": she is shown deciding upon revision, silence and the timing of performance. The audience's difficult questions are not instantly extinguished. Committee members, artists and child listeners leave with different rights and responsibilities as hearers.

There is also a critical limitation: the artist and Padma answer the organiser's proposals almost every time in remarkably explicit ethical language; less articulated interests, emotional mistakes and ruptures of tone may find too little room. Yet Lava's trembling voice, the king's unanswered silence, Phulmati's pause in singing and the girl's refusal of a role produce genuine aesthetic resistance within this didactic tendency. The final blackboard statement—that a king can listen, but does not write down every voice—expresses the chapter's concern with narrative authority; it is not a verdict establishing a historical event.

Chapter 210 — Bhamati's Fourth Sutra

Text, Interpretation, Objection and Today's Question: The Structure of Four Pages

There is an ink stain beside "tat tu samanvayat" on Mrinal's blackboard. Instead of wiping it away to make a handsome page, she decides to read the text first. Four separate pages—text, interpretation, objection and a question from the present—give the chapter's narrative structure a material form. The philosophical subject of the sutra is the purport of statements concerning Brahman, not voting in a community committee. The characters themselves explain the distinction. Criticism must therefore treat this episode not as a policy proved by philosophy but as the dramatic event of a text being placed in a new context.

In Ramesh Ghasi's absence, the phrase "unanimous cooperation by all artists" is entered in the minutes. "Coordination" thus becomes a practical misuse of a word: supporting an event and providing instruments without payment are not synonymous. The modern scene and the ancient study-room scene echo one another verbally, not causally. The narrator does not announce the meaning of a Sanskrit sutra and thereby settle a social question; instead the text exposes the discomfort of using one sutra-word as a cover for administrative consensus.

Bhamati's Study Room: A Woman's Editorial Intervention

Vachaspati, Bhamati, Mrinal and Lohana appear in the imagined study room of ancient Mithila. Everyone's opinion has been entered on a revised page, but Lohana records the cost of a damaged copy and her own dissent. The moment when "everyone's opinion" turns silence into consent is a narrative turning point. Bhamati retains a question mark beside the revised original; she is not idealised simply as a learned woman who adds another sutra, but appears as a living custodian of editorial memory.

Mrinal recalls the rope-and-snake illustration of adhyasa, yet admits that discovering a false expression of consent on a labour slip does not establish the whole philosophical meaning of the sutra. This self-limitation within the ancient dialogue is noteworthy. Bhamati and Lohana keep the original copy, revised copy and incomplete page of expenditure separate. The gravity of scriptural exegesis and the labour of those who make its pages occupy a single sequence of scenes without swallowing one another.

The Artist's Voice: The Economic Extension of Time Within Narrative

Ramesh's account of dholak work separates an hour and a half of rehearsal, one day's use of the instrument and performance on stage into

three time-based activities. Proposed amounts are one hundred and eighty rupees for rehearsal, one hundred and fifty for use of the instrument and seven hundred and fifty for performance. Karun Damai distinguishes liability for ordinary wear from that for actual damage. These material particulars make the artist's voice more than a statement of protest: it participates in deciding how an arrangement will work. Reducing the stage's splendour should not make instrumental labour invisible.

The hundred and eighty rupees for rehearsal are received at once; a payment order is issued for the remaining nine hundred, but bank receipt is not established. At first the announcer omits Ramesh's name on stage; during a pause Tara shows the slip, and the announcement is corrected. The narrative sequence matters: audible credit on stage can change immediately, while money moves on a different timetable. To erase that temporal difference and write "justice was done" would destroy the source's precision.

Reading Names, Imagining Rivers and the Discipline of Interpretation

One pupil wants to identify "Kritasara," a term in an incomplete poetic passage, as a separate river. Mrinal points out that the full original sentence is missing, Hira specifies the conditions for contemporary water measurement, and Padma enters "incomplete text" in the source register. The scene in which a child's blue drawing of waves is labelled "imagination" reveals the narrative's implicit method: an artistic line is permissible, but it cannot be presented as a definitive map of present geography.

In this sequence the roll of honour for dead workers and the papers showing wages paid are also kept apart. Sarita's gaze rests on Urmila's outstanding dues, but she does not insist on making her dead daughter's life the proof of every example. This resistance allows philosophical reconciliation, correction of names and payment for labour to remain three separate story-generating sites.

Polyphony in Dialogue and the Risk of Didacticism

Harimohan's adversarial question, a woman's query about eligibility to ask questions, Ramesh's sounding instrument, a child counting beats and Bhamati's protection of pages are not one uninterrupted commentary; they are voices belonging to different social temporalities. The narrative makes an instrument sound in the middle of philosophical study. The time of intellectual concentration is interrupted by the artisan's fatigue and the child's laughter. Here polyphony arises not merely from the number of characters but from the unequal obligations borne by their speech.

A limitation remains: once again the reader is promptly given exact definitions of nearly every significant distinction, so that the process of discovery sometimes resembles the ideal discipline of a classroom. Nevertheless, Ramesh's unpaid balance, the dissenting page, incomplete "Kritasara" and the labour still owed behind the memorial resist closure in any single meaning of the sutra. The narrative achievement of the "fourth sutra" is not unanimity but the continued legibility of disagreements placed side by side.

Chapter 211 — Udayana's Remaining Argument

The Red Slip and Narrative Inequality at the Beginning

A thin red slip falling from Hamida Miriasin's ledger records that a performance was postponed and the fee remains unpaid. The opening scene is neither a proof of God nor a philosophical disputation; it is material notice of an artist's withheld income. Only then does Udayana's debate begin. This ordering brings the reader back to local life before engaging a large abstract philosophical opposition. "Remaining" acquires distinct meanings not just in reasoning but also in suspended payment and the unauthorised use of a song.

Padma first prepares two pages: Udayana's case and a strong Mimamsaka counter-position, the purvapaksha. A committee member wants to reduce the page of questions in the name of bereaved families; Sarita refuses the unauthorised use of her daughter Naira's death as a philosophical example. Grief thus ceases to be material freely available for public debate and becomes a distinct narrative boundary pertaining to the dead person and the family. The narrator offers no spiritual explanation for the cause of Naira's death.

Disputation in Imagined Mithila: The Dramatic Time of Conflict

In an imagined study room of ancient Mithila, Udayana and a visiting Mimamsaka resume their disputation. The guest has brought his dead friend's writing vessel; private loss is present amid the debate, but does not automatically make either side victorious. The cracked pot and an example involving seeds give concrete form to the philosophical claims. The time required for objection, a renewed question, reply and outstanding objection differs from the haste associated with the thin fallen page.

The guest's opposition is not merely "ignorant doubt." Difficult questions are recorded concerning the nature of an agent, natural processes, disease, floods and the suffering of the innocent. Udayana presents his position, but avoids claiming omniscient knowledge of why any particular person died. The scribe writes "purvapaksha remains," not "defeat." The narrative does not offer a decisive settlement of spiritual belief; its disputation allows the opposing voice complete sentences. This is an aesthetic arrangement of characters' ideas, not a formal doctrinal test conducted by the critic.

Binding the Book, Credit to Workers and the Counter-Position's Copy

An elderly woman who stitches books asks how two different pages can be bound together. A pupil's night labour as a copyist had previously been recorded only as an expense for the teacher's reply; Udayana creates a

separate payment entry for copying the opposing case. This does not signify acceptance of the philosophical response, but the material preservation of a dissenting voice. The novel embodies intellectual tradition through paper, thread, ink, time and labour.

The visitor does not want his dead friend's name placed in the title of the debate. His objection echoes Sarita's permission concerning Naira, but the life facts, eras and decisions in the two episodes are different. To make the ancient scene legal evidence for the modern musician's fee, or to prove Udayana's philosophical position by means of Hamida's slip, would violate the novel's own discipline.

Hamida's Song: The Limits of Sound and a Separate Date for Payment

Hamida is prepared to show a full copy of the insulting cuts made to her song to a restricted inquiry group, but not to broadcast them again at a public meeting. One member proposes replaying the insult in the name of demonstrating misuse; the singer refuses again. Her song ledger is not an exhibit for display but a record of memory, selection and professional work. Her laughter at two half-forgotten lines sung by a girl provides a moment of living creativity amid this bitterness.

Instead of whitewashing the original receipt on which a name was omitted, a dated correction is added. An old attendance sheet is not proof of payment; nor does the order for Ramesh's nine hundred rupees prove receipt in a bank. Hamida's fee for the present event has not been settled, although the decision to stop the insulting public use has been recorded. It is rejected that different artists' separate dues should be bundled under the single heading "artist payment." The narrative's precision resides in these negative findings: it is clear about what has not occurred.

The Final Two Pages: Narrative Uncertainty and Evaluation

At the end, two separate pages hang on the wall: philosophical position, counter-position, unanswered question and imagined scene on one, and artistic use, correction, dues and permission on the other. Thought and economic events appear together, yet their methods of establishing truth differ. Hamida leaves with her ledger, humming half a melodic phrase; the sound, like the payment, remains unfinished. Binding two sides with paper thread does not create an image of final agreement.

The chapter's strength lies in refusing to turn a formidable opponent into a weak straw figure, or grief into an ornament of ideas. Its limitation is that, amid the carefully balanced replies of Udayana, the visitor, Padma and Sarita, relatively little space remains for the disorderly voice of a person who is overwhelmed, impulsive or unable to understand. At times

the disputation resembles an orderly seminar rather than artistic drama. Yet the unpaid dues, the exhaustion of grief and the night copyist's labour firmly establish the narrative reality of the counter-position.

Chapter 212 — Gangesha's Classroom

The Question That Was Not Erased and the Nameless Labour of History

The chapter's opening sentence starts with a girl wiping a blackboard. She does not want to erase the question "From whose life shall we take the example?" Mrinal adds the next date beneath it. With that action, the day changes but the question does not. Alongside it stands Hema Dev's old history-exhibition ledger, containing ten men's names and one line about women's unnamed labour. Two legible names, one incomplete name and an indistinct mark define the limits of the source from the outset.

While the present-day class reads the names of the four pramana divisions of Tattvacintamani, a student adds a fifth division concerning God. Mrinal corrects the mistake without humiliating the child. This brief dialogue safeguards both the "right to read" and the actual structure of the text. Freedom for ordinary readers does not authorise erasure of a particular work's scholarly divisions; it is instead a teaching relationship sustained by renewed questions.

Malati and Madhav Enter Gangesha's Imagined Study Room

The literary scene set in ancient Mithila is not a direct transcription of the real historical philosopher's biography. Malati Dhanuk's wet measuring vessel, the knot in boatman Madhav's rope and the pupils' textbook examples collide materially in the narration. Two vessels that look alike need not hold the same quantity; seeing the river's colour does not measure its present depth. Gangesha's class turns its gaze from fixed examples of pot and cloth towards the work of outsiders, although Gangesha himself does not mistake limited examples for a complete theoretical answer.

Malati, who asks questions, is not merely an object of knowledge. She brings an actual dispute about her loss of grain, a defective vessel and time spent working. A pupil draws the knots of Madhav's boat rope, yet the water's movement is not frozen in the drawing. Because of this incongruity, the chapter does not treat popular experience as an infallible rule; inquiry itself is shaped by the characters' commitments and purposes.

Listeners Define the Limits of Imagined History

A young woman in the present explicitly asks where the genuine old documents concerning Malati and Madhav are. Mrinal replies that their lives and dialogue are fictional creations of the novel, while Gangesha and the philosophical tradition belong to a separate historical frame of

reference. The episode matters not because an imagined scene has been "disproved" but because the narrative changes level: the scene of the ancient event becomes an object of public narration, and a listener asks for its historical basis. The novel itself acknowledges the imperfect correspondence between a literary world and primary sources.

In a dialogue about verbal knowledge, the date of testimony, its speaker, and whether the event was seen or merely heard about are kept distinct. A modern child raises the possibility that a labourer's experience can be mistaken; Padma insists that respect and verification are both necessary. This is a dramatic form for the reader's process of reasoning. To recast it in criticism as an independent scholarly treatise on epistemic proof would alter the nature of the chapter.

Hema's Supplementary Page: A Revised Account of Local History

Instead of filling the place of nameless women workers with a fictitious definite name, Hema separates two verified names, one incomplete name and the question of those who are absent. The committee has no authority to alter the school's main textbook immediately. It therefore approves, by a majority, a supplementary history page, source notes and their regular use in an open classroom. The result is limited: the supplement has been accepted and the original book remains unchanged. That uneven state makes it difficult to proclaim an unqualified victory that "history has been corrected."

The children decide not to take documents from private chests in their homes without permission. The number of women workers cannot be established conclusively from old kitchen expenses. Nasima's time spent repairing pages, Hema's copying, and the costs of contemporary printing and distribution are kept distinct. The spread of knowledge here extends beyond classroom interpretation to receipts, copies and permission from owners of sources.

Narrative Time and Critical Limitations

One day's present-time movement runs from the morning in which the girl wipes the blackboard to the evening reading of the supplementary sheet; the ancient classroom returns in several scene-fragments. The two are linked by the general question of "examples," but have neither a common agent nor direct historical causation. At the end, the absence of assistants' names from a printed philosophical book's title page explicitly foreshadows the dispute over credit in Chapter 213.

The chapter's achievement is that the wish to add women's names to history is not allowed to extinguish uncertainty. Its limitation is that the characters identify faulty generalisations almost as quickly as they propose

orderly alternatives; the unsettled anguish of doubt can diminish. Yet the unresolved dispute over measurement, the unchanged textbook and the schoolgirl's final unanswered question prevent the narrative from becoming a closed educational model.

Chapter 213 — Maithili's Own Voice

At the Printing Press: The Dramatic Crisis of Self-Acknowledgment

The new book's half-dried ink, Sarita's fingers and Maithili's red proof marks open the chapter. Maithili's credit as co-author has already been corrected, but Sarita's labour has remained invisible beneath the collective heading "assistance." The narrative's conflict is not simply a correction of wrongdoing by a villain: it shows someone who is making corrections repeating another mistake. In the first lecture, Maithili had incorporated Sarita's discovery of physical thread marks establishing the order of pages into her own account. The delayed acknowledgment of that act is the chapter's real internal event.

Maithili's written admission takes a definite form on paper: her failure to credit Sarita's observation promptly was a mistake in her own judgment. Sarita keeps a receipt for her work but makes clear that mentioning the labour and paying an old wage claim are separate things. She does not merge Urmila's outstanding dues into her own account. This three-way dialogue—an author's admission of wrongdoing, specific evidence of work and a financial obligation—is not dismissed with a single phrase of "moral forgiveness."

The Limits of Co-authorship and the Danger of Collective Praise

Ishaan wants to preserve the distinction between his original philosophical analysis and Maithili's established co-authorship. One draft says that "all the examples arose from community labour"; Maithili strikes it out as excessively general. A sweeping formula of honour often erases the finer distribution of credit. This is the chapter's distinctive literary concern. It is not enough merely to substitute several names for one authorial name: the original idea, revision, observation, printing and copying need separately identifiable voices.

Rama's earlier objection is to remain in the revision register; Maithili does not turn it into a public biography without Rama's consent. An elderly reader objects to printing the author's mistake, and that objection, too, remains intact in the printing house register. The chapter therefore offers no unbroken celebration of the "good editor," but includes a reader who disagrees with the right to correct a publicly written work.

Open Learning: The Compression of Rules and the Creation of Barriers

A notice requiring a prior certificate for advanced philosophical study wrongly compresses a complex teaching sequence. Training to handle

fragile original manuscripts, competence for higher study, introductory lessons and question sessions had been distinct; the later announcement reduced them to one line. Farid Chik's receipt with its corrected fee and Birsi's question expose the social consequences of this administrative compression. The narrator does not attribute the error solely to a repressive intention, but shows the institutional force of linguistic carelessness.

Child safety, protection of originals, entry to introductory study and private birth histories are given separate rules. Kabir does not make public the sealed envelope concerning his origins: entry to school requires minimal safe contact information, not an entire private genealogy. Eleven old applications survive, while five students had taken an outdated copy; two families receive the revised notice at once, and the remainder still have not been reached. Passing a rule and making it accessible remain different events.

Narrative Ethics: A Private Notebook, Printed Admissions and Unpublished Lives

Maithili publishes her own error, names Sarita's actual labour, and does not open Naira's private notebook. In this scene organised around multiple objects, "publication" is not inherently the supreme ethical act. Some lives become public, some passages remain restricted, and some persons are left to decide the terms of their own history. Sarita does not open a binding sewn by Nasima without permission. Naira's irreversible death does not negate the genuine pleasure of acknowledging labour; the loss retains its separate emotional time.

Printing costs are a real obstacle, so Maithili is willing to remove half a page of self-praise. Sarita's laughter lightens the human tension in this economic rejoinder. The space left in the margin of the last printed page for a future correction does not mark the end of credit-giving, but an admission of editorial incompleteness. "One's own voice" here is not unrestrained authorial command; it is the risk of acknowledging a fault and publishing a new sentence.

An Assessment of the Chapter's Craft

The chapter connects two parallel present-day crises—the book's preface and the school's rules—through the same characters' movements and their rewriting of pages. There is no directly dramatised scene from the ancient narrative strand; the consequences of the preceding philosophical lessons emerge as contemporary forms. Narrative time passes through different hours of the day and repeatedly returns to the press. Extensive self-criticism through dialogue sometimes reduces the reader's freedom to infer. Yet Maithili's half-dried ink, Sarita's rejection of the word

"inspiration," Farid's working time and Naira's closed notebook prevent the scenes from becoming merely a report of corrections.

Chapter 214 — Naira's Empty Place

The Entry of a Household Object and the Irreplaceability of Absence

The chapter begins when a grain of rice is removed from the edge of a brass plate. Sarita's work has been named in print, but not one letter of the emptiness caused by Naira's death has been reduced. This opening statement, placed immediately after the previous chapter's hopeful conclusion at the press, announces an incongruity. Sarita picks up the plate and walks towards the river landing: the narrative of grief enters ongoing labour and the exchange of communal objects rather than a static memorial.

Before the ceremony at the landing, someone asks why there is no safe path for washerpeople carrying their bundles. Urmila's older measurements are cited, but the present slope of the earth is surveyed anew. A dead person's memory can suggest a course of action in present work, yet present conditions do not permit the old measure to be applied unchanged. The laughter of Rukhsana and Renu does not reduce Urmila to a lifeless garland; it preserves the living distinctiveness of her behaviour.

Many-Voiced Naira: Resistance to Excessive Glorification

An organiser proposes the slogan "Naira: the immortal guardian of the landing," along with the assertion that she had foreseen everything. Sarita refuses, and Kabir recalls his disagreements with Naira and mistakes she made. This polyphony protects the deceased woman's human complexity from devotional omniscience. Sarita does not tear up the proposal; she asks that the history of revisions to the false publicity and the sources of donations also be checked. Narrative ethics here means a sequence of public accountability rather than merely beautiful language of tribute.

Small memories—Naira folding clothes the wrong way, correcting a vowel mark in someone's name on a photograph, and making an error when taking a picture herself—render her incomplete, disputatious and capable of making others laugh. Kabir laughs in a tea shop; that laughter is not a ceremonial tribute repeated from the memorial platform. In this modest return to objects, grief and humour become possible together without either cancelling the other.

Anupama's Letter: The Narrative Boundary of Limited Consent

Anupama Sen brings not her grandmother's original Bengali letter but a restricted copy of two lines concerning the expense of repairing books for which permission has been granted. Personal relationships, addresses and the names of living descendants are concealed. The copied text is marked

with its original language, date and purpose; Sanket asks for renewed permission before taking a photograph. The desire to read a page and the right to disseminate it publicly are distinct. The private source governs the story like a silent character without appearing on stage.

A proposal is made to keep verified copies at three sites, but no rule has yet been settled for reconciling future changes among them. The convenience of consulting one copy through another differs from the fear that one person could publish the whole family's letters. The narrator does not automatically equate circulation with liberation: ownership of the source, the privacy of others mentioned in the letter and the expense of verifying copies remain within the story.

Refusing to Invent Replies from an Absent Person

Kabir wishes to imagine Naira's answer to a letter he never sent. Sarita treats it as his own writing, not Naira's reply. Tara proposes identifying Naira with certainty in an unclear group photograph; Sarita accepts the uncertainty. In both episodes the aesthetic use of absence is plain: the deceased person's focalisation is unavailable to the narrator. Survivors describe their memories, but do not provide an omniscient interpretation of the dead person's mind.

The final washing of the plate, the refusal to give the empty place a new name, and the continued closure of Naira's private notebook are not simply negative symbols: they are the last visible actions of the scene. Grief becomes a bodily, repetitive daily routine rather than an abstract proposition. Other characters finish their work, but Urmila's dues and Naira's absence remain. This incompleteness is the narrative's deliberate emotional rhythm.

Achievement and Limitation of the Craft

The broom, broken step, narrow path, ritual decoration, song and repair markings at the landing coexist with remembrance of the dead without becoming synonyms for it. No final speech closes the scene of mourning. Nevertheless, the organiser's exaggerated proposal and Sarita's immediately articulate refusal can cast the dispute as a moral lesson rather than a human mistake. Unsettled donations, a mistaken photograph, an unsent letter and the bamboo leg of a table resist such neatness.

Chapter 215 — Distributed Records

The Fourth Clearing of the Pond: Recurrence Over Long Time

The chapter describes the fourth communal clearing of the pond in four years, in Chaitra of 2042. At the opening, Gomati first orders the making of a safe embankment; the protection of living bodies is more urgent than saving an attendance list of names. The scene returns the first chapter's conflict between kitchen and record to a new social arena. Pond silt, the stalks of makhana, a broken sandal strap and the measurement of breaks from cleaning draw narrative time away from claims about a long history and into a single working day.

The first half concerns numbered labour slips, hours, rest periods, wage rates and separately protected private identities. One worker's half-hour break has been deducted twice; testimony is compared and a correction made without erasing the original mistake. A child carries a basket into dangerous mud. Gomati acknowledges what the child says about the work, but simply calling hazardous child labour "attendance" is not an adequate remedy. The narrative separates the recognition of labour from the duty to ensure safety.

Coloured Pages, Differentiated Access and the Narrative Agency of Objects

White pages contain public accounts, blue pages are for authorised inspection, and a brownish cover protects private particulars. These colours are not decoration: they make visible who may see what, correct it or circulate its photograph. Rama Karna brings not the government office's original register but a certified copy of her earlier refusal, an acknowledgment number and a written request. Here the author speaks honestly about the complexity of where an "original" belongs: distributed record-keeping does not mean unlawful seizure of a government register.

A glossy corporate proposal offers to store every copy in a central repository and provide convenient mobile certificates. Gomati asks what becomes of a labourer's claim when there is no network; the company gives no clear answer. A volunteer fears that multiple copies will produce confusion. Rama admits that three copies can also produce three mistakes; dates of correction, previous forms, responsible persons and procedures for reconciliation are therefore necessary. Neither technology nor the sheer multiplication of copies is a miraculous cure.

A Pause for Voting: A Narrative Leap of Months

In the middle of the chapter, the narration suddenly moves several months forward to an open-account, public-reading and song assembly in Kartik. This leap matters: work on the site in Chaitra and a policy decision in Kartik are not achievements of the same day. Between them lie proposals, inspection, estimation of costs and preparations for a secret vote by members. A woman worker speaks of fearing to raise her hand against a contractor in his presence; a secret ballot and the right to a written minority view are agreed. An utterance from the audience changes the procedure of the meeting.

Counting of votes is public, individual votes anonymous. Distribution of copies is approved by a majority, while the minority objection that additional copies can spread errors survives in the minutes. Three distinct custodian signatures and a three-month costing proposal give the institution a new present tense; no single hand holds every key. The narrative does not merely proclaim "democracy": it shows children's non-voting participation, adult voting rights, the visible presence of dissent and the division of remuneration for custodial work.

The Narrative of Unequal Speeds of Payment

Two entries concerning time in the old pond-attendance record have been corrected, but one payment figure remains incomplete, and a worker wants payment by bank transfer. The statutory procedure, the order and actual arrival of funds are three different states. Rama makes public a summary of her earlier written objection—"I do not accept verbal pressure"—without disclosing the identity of a confidential witness. Investigation of the original register remains unfinished. Sarita does not surrender either her privately withheld dues or Naira's private phone to the authority created by the new public decision.

A woman at the end asks to be able to show her work slip at home: this is a dramatic reclaiming of social time for much informal labour. Another woman wants to learn surveying skills before the next pond clearing. Through this small transfer, characters cease to be spectators of a community institution and become possible agents in its next working process. The arrangement to keep three copies of records is alive only while people remain who can read the written pages and challenge them.

Overall Assessment of Narrative Craft

The narrator brings together a recurrence across four years, the moment of a sandal breaking, and a final voting scene separated by months. This movement between scales turns the record from passive information into an eventful arrangement of a worker's day. A limitation is that regulations

and explanations emerge too promptly and neatly in dialogue; workers' conflicting desires can become merely the "proper question" required by a proposal. Yet the woman who does not want her private name printed, the dissenting voter, the erroneous mark, child safety and Sarita's final empty water vessel reject any triumphal proclamation of complete equality.

Chapter 216 — Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind

The Return of the Title: From the First Kitchen to the Last Rice

The final chapter opens with Sarita moving a stick in her stove. The kitchen fire first seen when an official notice declared the living Sarita dead reappears after Naira's actual death. This is a recurrent opening-and-ending design, not a mechanical cancellation of the initial problem. Sarita removes a black pebble from the rice; Naira used to be impatient when picking through the grains. The memory of her daughter enters suddenly through a household action, not through a miraculous return staged by the narrator.

Kabir draws water using the well's pulley, Sanket brings a peg for the cupboard, and Tara describes the comparison of ballot copies. Administrative pages arrive as far as the home, but Sarita refuses to let them extend without end into mealtime. She refuses to treat trust and scrutiny as opposites. Stove-smoke, water in a metal vessel, the edge of a plate and evening sounds compress the novel's extensive public criticism once more into bodily time.

The Division of Household Labour and the Polyphony of a Meal

Gomati asks who will count the hours spent sorting rice, heating water and cooking meals at home when hours of pond work are counted. Sarita's answer is not merely to demand a seal: she asks, "Who will do this work every day?" Those present begin to consider a real division of food-preparation duties among family members; the narrative does not declare the problem fully solved. The unequal repetition of everyday obligations is not automatically erased by distant institutional justice.

Kabir serves too much rice onto Ruhani's plate; she asks him to take half back, and he adjusts it. To share food is not to impose identical portions, but to allow each person to say how much they want. A momentary disagreement over salt raises laughter. The humour does not erase floods, deaths or delays in court, but grants people the space to remain alive together on that evening. In these brief exchanges, the narrative authority of the entire epic assumes the form of household action.

The Unfinished Time of Naira's Absence

Naira's special bowl, rice scrapings, her mistake when folding clothes, and Tara's unanswered question are differently shaped memories. The characters do not transform Naira into an omniscient protector, an infallible corrector or a returned spirit. Tara says that she cannot finish her question; Sarita refuses to expose what remains private in the closed

notebook. No one has the right to gather up all of the dead person's voices. The story keeps distinct forms of silence—an unsent letter, an unopened notebook, an empty chair—without merging them into one sentimental emblem.

River water changes form as vapour, soil and other streams, but Sarita knows distinctly that the water cycle will not return her dead daughter in the same body, with the same voice and the same disagreements. The sense of an immeasurable universe does not diminish an individual death. This is an important poetic restraint in the final chapter: the cosmic metaphor does not claim to solve grief; its relativity is laid bare before irreparable loss.

Incomplete Records: Narrative Acceptance of Unresolved Outcomes

Gomati points out an error in a worker's marked payment box; there is no news that the original amount has reached its recipient. Tara immediately rises to correct it, but Sarita asks her to note the slip's time and eat first. At the door Rama Karna promises another check the next day, without intruding on the meal. Responsibility for public work and time for personal life do not cancel one another, but neither must every task be finished today.

The schoolchildren ask whether the cupboard will be opened the following day. The newly printed preface contains an admission, but the next edition must still make room for a child's objection. Javed's programme carries separate dues for artists, the injured dog's treatment takes time, and Urmila's unpaid balance remains on the historical page. These small story-arcs thwart the expectation of a "grand conclusion." Narrative completeness is not the reduction of every social difficulty to zero; it is the reader's departure with a sense of who still has work to do.

Focalisation, Duration and the Final Scene

The narrator remains in the third person, but the arrangement of scenes draws close to Sarita's body, memory, hunger and quiet responses. A few thin analepses—the notice announcing the living Sarita's death, Naira's mistake in the kitchen—strengthen Naira's absence within the final evening. A long history and the struggles of 216 chapters are condensed into the recurring plate, yet the narrator does not tell the reader that "everything remaining has been proved." The final action is this: Sarita puts a fallen grain of rice back into the bowl, serves Kabir and begins to eat herself.

It would contradict the source to read this grain as Naira's rebirth, a victory over death through the river, or the family's complete healing. Saving the grain is an ordinary act of care; it does not fill Naira's empty

place. The doorway stays half open to let the air in. This ending is more poetic than a rhetorical declaration that "the story goes on": daily human life continues, death cannot be reversed, and the questions will still be there tomorrow.

Aesthetic Achievement and Objections to the Novel's Ending

No god, omniscient judge or single great individual resolves every dispute at this ending. Water, rice, bamboo, scrapings, a question board and the arrangement of three keys make up its material world. The inner struggle named in the original title, Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind, acquires a new language as external warfare concludes: checking or trusting, memory or imagination, a woman's name or her work, grieving or eating. These oppositions do not disappear inside one unifying formula.

There is a limitation: most characters in the final gathering respond in considered and almost consistent language; a many-layered society can seem unnecessarily well ordered. Yet Sarita's bodily pause before death's reality, Tara's unanswered question for Naira, an incorrect payment mark, Kabir's closed letter and unequal appetites at the meal are incongruent facts of life that continually diminish the possibility of a final speech. The novel ends with the woman with whom it began actually eating her own meal: a smaller occurrence than a proclamation of liberation, but emotionally grave.

Svargarohana Parva / Uttara Kanda: Overall Narratological Assessment of Chapters 205–216

Narrative Levels: From Ascent to Heaven to the Rights of Living Listeners

At the beginning of this parva, the heavenly register of justice (205), Uttara and Parikshit's living future (206), Janamejaya's question about vengeance (207), and Ugrashrava's community of listeners (208) create not a single final period of epic time but layers of retelling. Chapter 209 then brings Lava and Kusha's singing in the royal assembly beside a present-day singer's authority over her own voice. Chapters 210–212 contain distinct imagined study scenes involving Bhamati, Udayana and Gangesha; Chapters 213–216 conclude through modern printing, the landing, collective institutions and the kitchen. The succession is not a straightforward chronological history: the novel changes the centre from which stories are heard.

The ancient range of the story-world grows out of questions involving kings, teachers and pupils; the modern range grows out of the lives of singers, workers, copyists, elderly women, children and grieving families. It would be wrong to treat the inclusion of both eras as literal proof or a one-to-one reincarnation of characters. The literary relationship consists in transferring questions: who may tell a story, who will hear it, who has the right to change it, and when may a listener object?

Song, Disputation and the Book: Three Internal Systems of Narration

The singing of Lava and Kusha tells the epic's story within the epic; Rama becomes one of the listeners to an account of his own life. Bhamati's pages survive as original, variant copy, objection and present-day question. In Udayana's dialogue, the opposing position is bound into the book; Gangesha's imagined classroom is examined anew when a listener questions its historicity. The story thus makes its own means of telling visible: song, copying, ledger, question-board, stage and publication. From a critical standpoint this is self-conscious narrative construction.

Present-day Phulmati, Karim, Ramesh and Hamida have different relationships to music, which are compared with ancient singing; this does not assert that a dispute over ownership of folk music reproduces historical regulations from the era of Lava and Kusha. The caution itself carries literary beauty: similar feelings can have unequal social consequences, sustaining a tradition of storytelling without making every era identical.

Recurrence of Narrative Time and Unsettled Intervals

The parva's long temporal line is composed of several different periods of ancient narrative, present-day days in 2042, the clearing of the pond in Chaitra, voting in Kartik, and abrupt analepses in personal memory. In particular, the fourth pond clearing in Chapter 215—the fourth in four years—evokes the seasonal or annual recurrence of communal labour; rules are then shown being made after a lapse of months. Chapter 216 brings objects from several earlier times into a single evening, yet contracts the whole breadth of time around a domestic fire.

Every completed action leaves an unfinished outcome nearby: an advance for singing has been received, but not the full honorarium; Ramesh has received rehearsal money, but only an order for the balance; Hamida's insulting use has been stopped, but an earlier fee remains due; Hema's supplementary page is approved, while the original book is unchanged; Maithili's preface has been corrected, but not all outstanding amounts paid; the records have reached three sites, while the inquiry into the original and future reconciliation remain unfinished. Such incompleteness constitutes the continuing time of narrative history, not inevitable pessimism.

Women's Perspectives, Unnamed Labour and Memory of the Dead

Sarita, Maithili, Bhamati, Mrinal, Phulmati, Hamida, Hema, Gomati, Rama, Tara, Anupama and Ruhani do not speak with one voice. Some choose words for a public song; others seek credit for arranging pages, limits on the use of primary sources, recognition of working hours, or the right not to have private life printed. In their differences, the women are not a decorative cluster of moral icons but a current of narrative personalities whose decisions are unequal.

Naira's absence gains particular force at the end of the parva. The initial problem of birth and death registers cannot alter her death. After losing her daughter, Sarita does not put a triumph of documents in the place of actual grief. Urmila's labour dues remain distinct from measurements at the landing; errors, laughter, weariness and complaints survive in personal memory. To manufacture a "complete" version of the dead is no proof of love; the narrative's impact arises from accepting this.

Questions of Craft: Useful Clarity Versus Narrative Over-Direction

The characters repeatedly articulate the differences among permission, credit, receipt, original, copy, privacy and public decision in precise language. The advantage is that the story does not thread many cases blindly onto one mystery. The artistic danger is that life's difficult moments become "examples" in an ideal manual of procedure. Opposing

characters' reasoning, awkward silences, internal contradictions and new uncertainty in the narration could all have been given more room.

That danger is counterbalanced by small failures in love, children's reasoning, organisers' mistakes, unpaid wages, Mrinal's admission "I did not understand," an unsent letter, and Sarita's pause over a grain of rice. The craft is most effective where the novel does not deliver a rule but leaves an object behind—an ink-stained page, closed notebook, lost name, empty plate or saved grain of rice.

The Whole Novel: A Narratological Assessment

The Combined Narrative Design of 216 Chapters

This structure is not the narrow biography of a single heroic protagonist. It is a long narrative with many densities of events: domestic life, archives, river geography, labour, communication, medicine, violence, law, love, death and community education. The chapter-and-parva sequence generates epic expectations, but in the modern period a many-sided ordinary routine takes precedence over final royal reconciliation or divine resolution.

The ancient narrative strand is not merely an allusion through character names: numerous scenes have been composed with their own narrative time, questions from characters, rhythms and limits on what listeners know. The philosophical episodes involving Bhamati, Udayana and Gangesha are places where things are heard, understood and changed inside the story; they are not scientific proofs of classical conclusions. The criteria of the overall criticism have accordingly been sequence of events, focalisation, narrative level, duration, recurrence, characters' voices, readers' expectations and structural pause.

From the Opening Mystery to Irreversible Loss at the End

In the first chapter, the paradox of a record declaring a living Sarita dead created a mysterious narrative point of departure. In the last chapter, the kitchen that first appears in the wake of the death notice returns after Naira's actual death as the necessary workplace of a continuing life. Correcting the name of someone erroneously listed as dead and being unable to restore a dead person's body form an opposition at the emotional centre of the novel. A convincing analysis of this recurrent design must rest on the real actions of the first and final chapters, not on an imagined mystical prophecy in the stove.

The old list of twenty-seven names, faulty registers, questions of permission and revisions to public history are large threads in the narrative; nevertheless each character has other lives on separate narrative ground. One person needs medicine, another the price of cloth, another her own song, another a safe pond, and someone else merely time to ask a question. To reduce the entire novel to the pursuit of a single criminal would diminish its multi-centred communal structure.

Objects, Places and Sounds in the Reader's Memory

The stove, kitchen utensils, railway gate, planks of a boat, pages in a chest, scraps of cloth, bamboo pegs, dholak beats, half-dried ink and river water

perform specific functions in their respective chapters. They do not form one fixed "master symbol"; as circumstances change, their uses change too. A song from one era is not a measurement made on another day, evidence from one copy is not someone else's private letter, and a dead worker's name on a memorial does not constitute payment. The recurrence of such differences gives solidity to the book's material structure.

Recurring sounds—the train, the boatman's calls, the instrument's rhythm, the silence within a folk song and the bubbling of a stove—create small stretches of duration within the long prose. The narrative is most effective at such moments when its articulation of emotion follows the action of an object or sound, rather than preceding it as an instruction.

Focalisation and the Individual Rights of Characters

The third-person narrator can approach many characters' mental states, but scenic proximity does not remain fixed at one centre. Sarita's kitchen, Naira's inquiry, Fakira's crossing, an artist's receipt, Gangesha's imagined classroom and the children's questioning ground grant readers different limits of knowledge. This shifting focalisation produces multiple character-centred perspectives in place of an announced all-knowing authority. Yet at times the narrator explains the inward meaning of a character's response outright, narrowing what readers might infer independently.

An important ethical and aesthetic rule of the novel is not that every character is invariably correct; rather, it regards the complete narrative capture of one person's private experience by another as illegitimate. Sarita therefore does not write Naira's unwritten reply to a letter; Kabir does not let uncertainty about his birth erase the life of his foster mother; Phulmati does not sing an old humiliating line on stage. Different forms of narrative authority are dramatised in different chapters.

Precisely Identifying Weaknesses in the Craft

One challenge of epic range is that bringing together numerous timelines, social groups and classical intertexts in the chapters can compress the distinct emotional rhythms of particular episodes. Characters' excessively procedural speech can occasionally turn audible life into something like editorial instructions for the book. The recurring insistence on separating sources is warranted, but if nearly every character promptly demonstrates the same maturity of explanation, their individual worlds of language may begin to sound alike.

A further danger appears when an ancient story becomes too exact a modern reflection of a contemporary question: readers may see the analogy proposed by the author instead of the historical difference between eras.

The novel often averts this risk by identifying imagined stories as imagined, keeping source-periods distinct and refusing to treat a poetic name as a measurement of place. A critical assessment should preserve both this achievement and the possibility of remaining lapses of care.

Conclusion of the Overall Assessment

The final achievement of the complete 216-chapter narrative is an ending in which the autonomy of working people, the irreversibility of death, named recognition of women's labour, uneditable portions of private memory and the time needed for communal institutions to improve all coexist. Epic breadth here is not assumed to be proved merely by a count of characters or parvas. Its question is tested in a new age through a plurality of rights to speak. Unevenness in craft from page to page, an occasional over-prompt clarity of ideas and the didactic repetition of several procedures demand criticism; these objections, however, do not cancel the literary importance of the work's human questions centred on labour.

At the end there is no hero's throne but Sarita's plate; no cry of victory but a half-open door; no infallible prophecy of the future but a mistake to be checked the following morning. Naira does not return, yet rice is cooked. Keeping these unequal simultaneous truths intact constitutes the novel's final courage as a narrative.

Incongruity and Narrative Method

Explanation, Evaluation and Final Conclusion

Incongruity: Not Necessarily a Flaw, but a Possible Method of Making a Story

In the long narrative of Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind, incongruity is not of one kind. Sometimes a character's living body and a government entry contradict one another; sometimes two witnesses give differing accounts; sometimes an old text and a new map do not coincide; sometimes one scene uses the same object differently from another. But not every difference is automatically a creative achievement either. The centre of literary scrutiny should be which differences alter the reader's knowledge, focalisation, sense of time or a character's autonomy, and which remain as unintended carelessness in the construction of the story.

This conclusion rests on the actual course of events in the novel, not on a desire to impose an external theory upon it. Narratology helps clarify how incongruity functions by distinguishing a story-event from the form in which it is narrated. Two different entries do not constitute one truth in the story-world; two differing speakers are not necessarily liars; coexistence with another timeline is not itself historical continuity. Incongruity takes meaning through the interaction of an event's context, information held by the narrator, the character's limited knowledge and the reader's expectations.

The Opening Death Register and the Inequality of Death at the End

In Chapter 1, "The Dead Person's Kitchen," Sarita is alive but receives a death notice issued in her name. She tends the stove, sustains relationships and questions the administration about her existence. The incongruity is made within the world of events: written death and a living body coexist. The plot gains its movement from that distance. The reader is not first handed a verdict on who made the error, but must read different life histories, forms, oral statements, private pages and forms of responsibility.

In Chapter 216, Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind, the kitchen returns, but Naira's death is now real. To make the erroneous notice of death in the first chapter and the irreversible grief of the last into an identical symbol would be both ethically and artistically mistaken. The first narrative concerns a status of names that can be corrected; the last faces a loss that no correction notice can undo. The strength of the recurrent design lies in altered meanings inside the same objects—rice, stove and plate. Similar scenes depict fundamentally unequal circumstances.

Archival Incongruity: Creating Mystery and Delaying Resolution

In "Twenty-Seven Names," the number gives the reader an illusion of possessing a complete list, but a copy containing twenty-six names and the decision to keep one name sealed perform different functions. This is not an arithmetic error, but the story of differing temporalities of consent, evidence and public circulation. Permission to open another layer is deferred; the wish to investigate and control over a name are not lodged in the same character's hands. The resistance suspends readerly curiosity, and the suspension acquires the force of narrative ethics.

In "Fourteen Discrepancies," "A Convenient Error," "The Original Page" and several chapters about signatures, differences between copy and original initiate story-lines. An altered spelling of one name, reversed times for one journey, or multiple administrative statuses assigned to one person do not amount to advance declarations of definite crime. Separate records enlarge what the reader knows without necessarily fixing the truth. What first seems decisive can become partial when a subsequent scene is encountered. Contradiction thereby becomes a mechanism of narrative expansion.

Displaced Narrative Time and Modern Rereading of the Epics

The episodes from the ancient Mahabharata, Ramayana, and the Bhamati–Udayana–Gangesha traditions are not arranged as ordinary flashbacks within a linear history of modern Videhapur. Many appear as independent scenes, after which the lives of modern characters enter. These chapter divisions require the reader to hold experiences from two distinct times together. Not every scene demonstrates that ancient figures are the direct ancestors or reincarnations of contemporary characters, or a biological continuity of identical names.

The method creates distance as well as resemblance. Draupadi's question can resonate with a modern woman's question about labour or consent without making the historical circumstances identical. At the level of narrative order, scenes from distinct eras illuminate one another critically; in the objective time of the story they remain separate. Incongruity here is not an error in chronology but the craft of a dual-temporal composition, provided that the narrative preserves the independent character of both eras.

Shifting Proximity of Focalisation and the Narrator's Limited Omniscience

The third-person narrator of the novel approaches Sarita's domestic routine, Naira's research, Fakira's crossing, the boatman's measurements, the weaver's work and the singer's experience from varying distances. Not

every scene is seen from one centre. Someone classified by a single word on an official sheet possesses, from their own perspective, an identity composed of several relationships. However extensive the narrator's information, a character's distrust, memory or refusal is not wholly erased.

For this reason, converting conflicting experiences into a unanimous account would extinguish the reader's responsibility. The strongest scenes are those in which one person's written conclusion changes in the presence of another. A weakness emerges when numerous characters supply similarly orderly explanations; at those moments polyphony appears as prepared argument rather than living disagreement. The aesthetic force of incongruity depends upon escaping that limitation.

Spoken Words, Unsent Letters and Narratives of Silence

Public records, private notebooks, threatening phone calls, slips bearing names, unsent letters and the voice of songs are different narrative media inside the work. Ownership of a written word is not the same as the credibility of something heard. In Chapter 214, "Naira's Empty Place," the desire to invent a reply in the absent Naira's name is refused. This moment exposes a negative form of incongruity: the gap between a bereaved person's desire and the possible speech of the dead cannot be filled by making imagination pass as fact.

In the recitation of Lava and Kusha, folk songs, Mrinal's questioning and Maithili's decisions about language, rights of narration are repeatedly distributed anew. Who may tell whose story, who may approve it and whose name will survive in the text become formal subjects of the work. Scenes in which stories are heard, written and revised within the story make the novel reflect on its own mode of construction. Language here is not merely a means of reporting events but an active site of dispute.

Incomplete Results and the Craft of an Unresolved Ending

The novel repeatedly distinguishes between receipt of an application and remediation of an injustice. A wage order may be passed without money arriving in an account; a site plan may be approved while the river's current changes; permission for a programme may be granted while the artist's full payment is still due. In these examples, incompletion can portray different rates of social action rather than a defective ending to a plot.

In Chapter 215, "Distributed Records," circulation of multiple copies serves shared public control, but leaves the possibility of spreading errors among more copies. Even after a majority decision, the minority objection is not destroyed. In Chapter 216, a payment mistake remains unsettled amid the shared rice meal. Had the work resolved every question at once, the

opening contradiction would have remained merely an error corrected at the end. The unresolved ending transforms it into an ongoing responsibility of society.

Recurring Objects, Sound and Reversal of Narrative Meaning

Water, rice, bamboo, keys, scraps of cloth, coloured pages, boats, dholak and stove appear repeatedly. At each reappearance, an object does not preserve the exact meaning of its earlier occurrence. A boat may first be a means of travel, later an occasion for measuring risk, and sometimes a site of shared responsibility. A key can protect privacy and also become the subject of distributing authority. Recurrence creates a rhythm of memory across chapters.

Within that rhythm, incongruity makes the change of meaning possible: the same object raises a different ethical problem in different hands. Locking it into a single stable symbol would oppose this multidimensional meaning. At the novel's end, Sarita's plate is no mere declaration of victory; it brings together the labour of cooking, the memory of an absent person and the next day's unfinished work, allowing the reader to experience several temporalities together.

Contradictions, Opposed Testimony and Genuine Defects in Craft: Necessary Distinctions

Contradictions within the story and an author's unintended inconsistency against the text require separate criteria. If two characters record different times in an original chapter, and the scene investigates the reason for or consequences of the difference, it is part of narrative conflict. If an event remains unproved and the narrator acknowledges the uncertainty, it is not an error. But if an object, speaker, time or cause changes within the same scene and the story never recognises that change, it cannot be defended simply as "polyphony."

The first kind of difference is visible to the reader, experienced by the character, and worked upon by the narrative in its consequences. The second thrusts the reader, without reason, out of confidence in the story-world. At many points the novel explains distinctions between evidence, privacy, credit and justice with exceptional explicitness; such over-explanation can weaken characters' independent impulses. When ancient scenes become too precise a counterpart to a modern claim, the felt differences between historical worlds may also blur. Authentic criticism must acknowledge these limits even while recognising achievements of creative incongruity.

The Reader's Work: Attentive Co-Reading Instead of Impossible Totality

Incongruity requires additional labour from the reader. A ledger of life and an actual living body, a private letter and its public copy, a mythic declaration and a modern court form, memory and fact cannot substitute for one another. The reader must decide which information comes from a witnessed scene, a character's statement, a document or merely a future possibility. Not receiving one complete story at once is no deficiency in the reader; the novel makes the reader practise ethical judgment while knowledge is incomplete.

Yet the responsibility for constructing the basic events clearly cannot be handed entirely to the reader in the name of active participation. Coherent recurrence, credible memory of objects, contexts for opposed statements and recognisable signals of time are necessary. Kurukshetram of the Inner Mind succeeds where incongruity makes its reader more attentive rather than less trusting.

Conclusion: The Kurukshetra Within the Story

The journey through 216 chapters becomes not the lucid record of one individual's victory but an interlocking, incomplete history of relationships, archives, labour, death and memory. The incorrectly entered death at the beginning, the disputes over names, pages and shared ownership in the middle, the procedure of distributed records at the end and Naira's irreparable absence together create the many forms of incongruity. On one level the work seeks documentary correction of injustice; on another it acknowledges that human loss, silence, personal unwillingness and complex social time cannot be contained in a complete conclusion on paper.

Incongruity becomes a narrative method in this novel when shaped as a difference of scene, time, perspective or voice, and when the reader can recognise its artistic work. Incongruity is not a virtue in itself, but an accomplished story can turn that difference into a form for questioning, pause, resistance and memory. Sarita's last kitchen scene does not finish every dispute; it preserves the possibility that living people may begin life again. In this possibility, the "Kurukshetra of the inner mind" reaches its most poignant narrative meaning.

PART II / TOME VII

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Folk Lifeworlds, Language and Cultural Memory

Gajendra Thakur · English translations from original Maithili by the author himself · Videha

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STUDY 01 / NIT NAVAL

Yoganand Jha

CHAPTER 01 / 1986 • Second edition 2018

Folk Life and Folk Literature

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

1. Central Argument: The Inseparability of Folk Life and Folk Literature

At the outset, the author treats folk literature not merely as a repository of verse, stories, or entertainment, but as a living expression of the life of the people. The author's statement (pp. 11–32) discusses the meaning of the folk, the experiences of ordinary people, the diverse forms of folk literature, and the richness of Mithila's oral heritage. His concern is that village speech, occupations, beliefs, storytelling, and song have not been accorded the place they deserve in histories of written literature. From this perspective, the work is not simply a source of literary pleasure; it is also an attempt to assemble a social document.

Pages 12–13 of the original author's statement compare several systems of classification. Categories such as folk vocabulary, folk dance, folk theatre, folk ballads, narrative songs, folk songs, folktales, proverbs and idioms, oral traditions, proverbial or playful verses, folk incantations, and riddles establish the breadth of the field. The opening pages refer to ancient Sanskrit literature as well as modern scholarship. Yet classification is not itself a final truth: a single gahbar song may simultaneously be a folk song, a ritual, a remembrance of a community's history, and a public performance. Examples later in the book demonstrate this plurality of functions.

A necessary distinction here is that between folk and cultivated or learned literature. The author discusses oral transmission, collective composition, textual variation, meanings formed over time, and the spontaneous vitality of folk traditions. The distinction has critical value; nevertheless, any account of the folk must also allow for movement between the educated and the uneducated, town and village, singing and reading, customary community practices and contact with the written or printed word. In a gahbar song, for example, religious references to Kali, characters named in ballads, and local singing traditions coexist within the same performance.

In the preface to the first edition, the author registers the lack of systematic studies of Maithili folk literature. In the preface or introductory material to the second edition of 2018, he outlines more extensively the earlier research and collecting that had become available (pp. 4–10, 28–32). The dates of first

publication in 1986 and of the reprinted or second edition in 2018 matter: this is not a field report produced at a single moment, but a book in dialogue with the intellectual contexts of different periods.

From the Text of Folk Literature to Evidence of Folk Life

The book's method of organization has two distinct stages. First, it introduces communities, caste and subcaste names, occupations, lexical forms, objects of worship, and social customs. Second, it portrays those societies' values, conflicts, and aspirations through tales, ballads, and songs. This sequence makes it possible to read the world of work and the world of imagination not as separate domains but as interrelated ones.

There is, however, a risk in compressing older occupations, present-day livelihoods, religious observances, and social standing into a single linear account on the basis of community names alone. The book records caste terminology and views on etymology belonging to its original period. Contemporary research must therefore examine communities' own preferred names, changes in their conditions of life, and the diversity that may exist within a single designation. This observation arises from the historical and social context of the text; it is not a timeless allegation against any community.

2. The Social Character of Caste Communities: A Sequential Review of Six Sections

2.1 The Social Character of the Dom Community | pp. 35–42

This section opens with the position of the Dom community in Mithila's social order and with its bamboo craftsmanship. Describing traditional occupations, the author lists various household articles fashioned from bamboo and emphasizes the occupational vocabulary that developed around this work. This is one of the clearest places in the book where lexical wealth and the history of labour illuminate one another. Its particular significance is that folk culture resides not only in sacred narratives, but equally in everyday objects, techniques of manufacture, and productive labour.

Alongside mythic accounts of origin, the author gives space to the Dom community's social practices and song culture (pp. 35–41). In the origin narrative one can discern a tendency to confer legitimacy upon the varna order; the sociological meaning of such a story, however, is distinct from its historical veracity. It should be read as a belief circulating about a community. The extensive vocabulary of bamboo work is the more concrete and directly useful feature of the section.

The book's references to proverbs concerning the Dom community, songs associated with work, and customary conduct also disclose social attitudes towards the occupation. It would be a mistake to regard this material merely as amusement or as curiosity about old tales: it testifies to the ways in which social stratification shapes language and folk song. The present critical reading therefore calls for attention to potentially derogatory caste references within

such expressions and for the voices of the people being described to be included through their own testimony.

2.2 The Social Character of the Chamar Community | pp. 43–44

The section on the Chamar community is brief, but its place in the book's design is important. The author refers to leather, footwear materials, an older division of labour associated with dead animals, and traditions of caste surnames. The narrative account of origins reveals how closely occupation and caste were intertwined in popular belief. A contemporary critical study cannot reasonably confine an entire community to one occupation solely on the authority of such an origin story.

Of particular note is the discrepancy, implicit in the section, between the usefulness of labour and the social position of the labourer. Although the manufacture of objects is indispensable to collective life, those who perform the work do not necessarily enjoy corresponding respect. The words and folk expressions collected by the author open a way to study this paradox. Comparing pp. 43–44 with pp. 35–42 raises a question: how is the representation of the many communities that constitute the 'folk' to be determined in a collection of folk literature? This short section does not fully resolve the question, but it makes the need to ask it evident.

2.3 The Social Character of the Dhobi Community | pp. 45–49

The section on the Dhobi discusses washing, dyeing, cleaning, and other services associated with clothing. The author offers examples of familiar proverbs, specialized occupational vocabulary, folk songs, and social practices. The treatment of laundry work raises an important cultural question: what degree of social esteem has been granted to the labour that makes society's ideas of 'purity' and their practical observance possible? A critical reading of this contradiction is central to the section's potential significance.

The songs identify the social and musical environment of labour. Washing clothes is so commonplace an activity that its literary importance could readily be overlooked; yet by collecting expressions associated with the occupation, the author makes everyday practice an object of cultural study. It is possible to undertake some analysis of the songs' rhythm, forms of address, and repetition here. In the absence, however, of recordings of their actual sound, information about the singers, dates, and places, no definite claim about a specific performance tradition can be established.

Another dimension of Mithila's folk life—service, dependence, and reciprocal social exchange—emerges from this section. It can be read not merely as a narrative of caste origins but as a point of departure for a history of the exchange of labour. Nevertheless, the book does not provide contemporary economic statistics or figures for the present distribution of occupations.

2.4 The Social Character of the Halwai Community | pp. 50–52

In the section on the Halwai, the author presents views about the etymology of the name, indications of agricultural or commercial traditions, divisions

into subcastes, and descriptions of the worship of figures such as Ganinath and Govind. Here occupation is treated as a major basis of caste-cultural identity, but the account also incorporates folk belief, deities, and internal hierarchies. The details of subcastes and family worship on pp. 50–52 further show that the equation 'one caste, one occupation' is inadequate.

Its importance within the book's internal architecture grows because the later section on folk ballads discusses Ganinath–Govind, Feku Ram, and other figures belonging to the same world of belief. The usefulness of this method—social introduction first, narrative afterwards—becomes clear through the example. A distinction must nevertheless be maintained between the devotional prestige conferred by narrative and the history of a caste community. Describing the author's view is one thing; establishing it through scientific historical corroboration is another.

2.5 The Social Character of the Mallah Community | pp. 53–59

The section on the Mallah is relatively extensive within the book's social description. Its chief concerns are rivers, water, boats, fish, makhana (fox nuts), water-based livelihoods, and the folk world of river ghats. The author discusses occupational naming, presents associated subgroups and folk songs, and relates the use of aquatic resources to social life. A distinctive cultural geography of Mithila comes into view: water is not simply a natural setting but a subject of song, an instrument of labour, and a place where folk narratives unfold.

Pages 54–58 contain folkloric episodes associated with life's hardships, fishing practices, families, and the earning of a livelihood. Humour, everyday dialogue, and the experience of work come together in these passages. On p. 59, the author also signals concern about changing occupational conditions. From this perspective, the preservation of folk literature becomes inseparable from changes in natural resources, modes of production, and family labour.

The later sections of the book are essential to understanding the connections between Mallah traditions and Dulra Dayal and Garo Devi. The river-dependent labour described in the social introduction assumes the form of folk heroes, protective deities, and collective devotion in the ballads. Through this relationship, the two parts of the book illuminate one another.

2.6 The Social Character of the Kuredi Community | pp. 60–63

The Kuredi section pays particular attention to a distinctive livelihood: the collection of honey. Descriptions of vegetation, bees, elevated places, and seasonal risks evoke a world of knowledge dependent upon nature. The author discusses the term 'Kuredi', neighbouring occupational communities, and the names of subcastes. The material is important because oral histories of folk culture also preserve skills, the courage required to earn a living, and bodily expertise.

In sociological comparison, the Mallah community's knowledge of water and the Kuredi community's gathering of honey belong to the same broader category: practical knowledge developed through a local environment.

Further critical research could analyse the vocabulary, implements, working seasons, tree names, and risks described by the communities themselves. These possible lines of inquiry must not, however, be misrepresented as surveys actually conducted in the book.

The tradition of worshipping Beniram as a community deity among the Nau and Kuredi, mentioned later in the ballad of Beniram (p. 121), connects back to this social account. Livelihood, collective ancestral memory, and the conception of a deity thereby become mutually related.

3. Folk Ballads: Separate Studies of Fourteen Texts

The original work's section on folk ballads begins on p. 64. The individual accounts are not uniformly long: some offer brief narrative outlines, while others include extended narratives and passages of song. The present study therefore takes into account both the available length of each ballad and the state of the evidence. The terms 'hero' and 'deity' are employed here from the perspective of folk tradition; they do not imply that the persons concerned have been historically verified.

3.1 Shyam Singh | pp. 64–66

The story of Shyam Singh is closely associated with the Dom community. Through figures such as Shyam Singh, Vanshidhar, and Balaji, the narrative constructs scenes of human relationships, conflict, and valour. The author introduces the folk hero at the outset and, at the close, refers to the place of Shyam Singh's memory in the traditions of the Dom community.

In this ballad, questions of love and relationships, as well as of power, find expression in the language of heroism. The response to humiliation, the claims of family, and the impulse towards violent resistance are prominent in the unfolding story. Critically considered, the ballad becomes a figure for the imagination of collective dignity and for conflict with social hierarchy. It should be read as an account of how a folk community fashions an identity through memories of honour and protection, not presented as a verified chronology of political events.

3.2 Lalvan Baba | pp. 67–68

The section on Lalvan Baba presents a moving narrative of a folk deity associated with the Chamar community. Central to the story are the relationship between Lalaji or Lalvan and Mansaram, a woman's predicament, her rescue, and a violent outcome. Page 68 also recalls Lalvan through a community folk song.

A striking transformation in this ballad is that a person who faces human insecurity and social oppression eventually becomes an object of worship and a centre of collective remembrance. The making of a folk deity is often an imaginative combination of history, grief, resistance, and a shared sense of justice. The text presented by the author provides valuable material for critically examining this process.

3.3 Gariban Bhujra | pp. 69–73

Labour, poverty, neglect, and the suffering associated with earning a livelihood dominate the ballad of Gariban Bhujra. The original p. 69 contains references to folk beliefs, such as a tutelary deity associated with a washerman's furnace or work area; the story-song repeatedly describes Gariban's situation and addresses him directly. The name 'Gariban' itself opens a field of meanings associated with economic deprivation, but reducing the character to a mere symbol would obscure the suffering of the human figure at the heart of the narrative.

The possibility that a neglected individual can attain an honoured place in collective memory makes the ballad a form of social record. Yet one cannot take the entire narrative literally as the history of events that actually occurred. Studying its repetitive singing, imagery, and pathetic episodes helps us understand how folk society gives voice to the suffering of its working members.

3.4 Motidai | pp. 74–75

At the centre of 'Motidai' stand a female character's moral courage and her resistance to humiliation. Initially, Motidai appears as a householder devoted to daily worship; confronted with hostile intentions and pressure, she remains firm in her decision. The narrative also contains episodes of death and extraordinary consequences.

It would be reductive to read this ballad solely as a conventional tale about safeguarding feminine chastity. One can also discern a folk imagination of a woman's authority over her own body and decisions, although this modern language of rights is not the author's original formulation. The indications of women's struggle within the brief narrative on pp. 74–75 offer an important counterpoint to the book's predominantly masculine current of heroic ballads.

3.5 Ganinath–Govind | pp. 76–86

This is among the more expansive narratives in the work. The author connects the worship of Ganinath–Govind with the Halwai and certain other communities, and discusses folk beliefs attached to local places such as Rajpalvaiya in the Vaishali region (p. 76). The account brings together Ganinath's birth, encounters involving deities, Govind's role, collective human crises, and various episodes of religious recognition.

The chief characteristic of the ballad here is the intermingling of divine and human time. The figure of Ganinath brings together conceptions of fatherhood, protection, and communal welfare. The story of the deity unfolds alongside local geography and social ceremonies, allowing literature of faith to function as a means of social identification. The conjunction of the ballad and its traditional recognition on pp. 85–86 deserves close attention.

The critical question is where the Ganinath–Govind narrative expresses a truth internal to its storytelling tradition and where the author presents it as a

historical oral report. The book itself contains evidence of certain place names and worship practices, but such evidence does not establish that every extraordinary event in the story actually occurred. Maintaining this distinction is essential to a scholarly critical assessment.

3.6 Feku Ram | pp. 87–88

The narrative of Feku Ram belongs to the Kanu–Halwai community. It recounts the experiences of Feku Ram, his wife Sonmati, and a profound domestic crisis. The story develops through human desire, helplessness, and fidelity; at its close, there are indications of Feku Ram's elevation in folk memory.

The defining feature of this section is its brevity. The adversities of life and the marital relationship are transformed into a communal narrative of faith. Merely calling a figure such as Feku Ram a 'clan deity', without fuller historical context, would give the reader insufficient information. The book supplies a narrative thread that permits further investigation of its different oral versions.

3.7 Karikh | pp. 89–93

The 'Karikh' section traces the origin of a folk hero, family relationships, references to narratives concerning Dina-Nath, misfortune, and a sequence of conflicts or accommodations with deities. Passages intended for singing alternate with narrative prose. The figure of Karikh emerges from the precarious existence of folk society to assume the role of a collective protector.

An important insight emerges from a reading of this ballad: the legitimacy of a folk hero is often established not by state archives but by communal singing and ritual acts of remembrance. Pages 89–93 of the original supply the material for studying this transformation. If the rhythms, repetitions, and modes of address of the songs are treated as incidental and only the plot is read, a defining quality of the folk ballad is lost.

3.8 Dulra Dayal | pp. 94–96

In 'Dulra Dayal', the memory of a protective hero is linked to the Mallah community's social life and occupations. The section begins with references to the production of mangoes, betel leaves, fish, makhana, and other resources, alongside the life of the Mallah in Mithila. The story of Dulra Dayal then develops themes of lineage, family, rivalry, and remembrance.

Mithila's food culture and river-dependent life, described in the social section, become here the medium of heroic memory. The story of Dulra Dayal lends itself to studying folk values concerning communal rights, labour, and protection. On p. 96 the author indicates the devotion associated with this ballad within the community. This is evidence of its cultural significance, not of universal historical acceptance.

3.9 Garo Devi | pp. 97–100

The narrative of Garo Devi concerns the worship of a folk goddess among the Mallah and memories of family life. On p. 97 the author describes the

remembrance of Garo Devi, beliefs associated with ponds and water, and songs connected with celebrations of birth. The ballad carries the emotional accents of fathers and children, separation within families, and domestic crises.

The meaning of communal honour accorded to a woman as a deity differs here from its significance in the narrative of Motidai. Whereas moral resistance is central to Motidai, the Garo Devi material combines community, lineage, the watery environment, and blessings for a birth. In places, the recurrent forms of singing on pp. 97–100 perform the work of prayer. The composition crosses with ease the conventional boundaries between folk song and folk ballad.

3.10 Jai Singh | pp. 101–104

The ballad of Jai Singh tells of a celebrated man's bravery and the standing of his kinship community. At the beginning, the author refers to traditions concerning Jai Singh's worship. The story introduces Jasumati's children, family difficulties, places associated with the worship of Kamala, and episodes of devotion. The narrative is more clearly intelligible as a model within folk society than as a history of the state.

The ballad's lyrical construction gives a memorable figure a rhythmic expression in the public language of the community. Because the worship of heroes is widespread among a number of Mithila's communities, the Jai Singh text illustrates that the making of divinity belongs not only to the past but also to a continuing process of collective religious and social practice.

3.11 Amar Singh | pp. 105–107

The story of Amar Singh initially adopts the tone of historical heroism. It develops through struggles of retaliation, revenge, social protection, and local worship. Episodes involving the protection of a child, combat, and sacrifice are particularly prominent on pp. 106–107. The accompanying passages of song turn the hero's memory into an expression in the language of the people.

A responsible assessment of the ballad must preserve a distance between the glorification of the hero and the story's violent events. A folk ballad is a source for understanding communal conceptions of dignity, not an injunction to hostility towards any social group. The episodes supplied by the book may be researched as sources for narrative history; external archival verification of events, dates, and persons remains a separate undertaking.

3.12 Keval Maharaj | pp. 108–110

The ballad of Keval Maharaj is associated with the collective memory of the Mallah community. Expansion beyond seven seas, conflict, and the hero's elevation into a folk deity of his own community are its principal motifs. The original story begins with references to the 'seven seas' and an immense, mythical dominion. These must be understood as poetic hyperbole, not as evidence of royal geography.

The ballad's essential dramatic force lies in determination, steadfastness in adversity, and struggle on behalf of one's own community. The brief account on pp. 108–110 shows how, within a story, the elevation of a deity or folk protector can be bound to human courage. The employment of exaggeration in the folk ballad creates an emotional truth, not an independently verifiable historical truth.

3.13 Dina–Bhadri | pp. 111–120

Dina–Bhadri is one of the longer and most socially resonant sections of the book. The author enters the ballad through a discussion of agricultural labourers, particularly the Musahar community, and the inequalities of agrarian life. Children, labour, fields, oppression, bondage, resistance, and the recognition of folk heroes are interwoven within a single narrative. Here the story of a community's protector cannot be separated from its struggle for livelihood.

Passages describing economic deprivation and the hardships of cultivation on pp. 111–118 establish the ballad's social background. On pp. 119–120 the author clarifies Dina–Bhadri's place in community memory and their image as figures of struggle. The text can be read as folk memory's response to feudal or other relations of domination. 'Class resistance' is a critical perspective adopted in this reading, however, not a fixed term uniformly employed by the original author.

The ballad matters because the lived reality of labourers becomes its central literary subject. At the same time, exceptional heroism, folk belief, and collective aspiration converge. The text cautions the critic against imprisoning impoverished communities within the image of victimhood alone; equal importance must be given to their organization, self-respect, and imagination of resistance.

3.14 Beniram | pp. 121–133

The Beniram section records the worship of Beniram as a community deity of the Nau and Kuredi (p. 121). The author recounts in detail the depth of local belief, songs associated with birth, family relationships, and the courage of the central figure in difficult circumstances. This section includes a substantial number of lines meant for ballad singing; it is therefore not merely a summary of a story, but a rhythmic document of oral memory.

On pp. 122–128, the events of the plot unfold alongside scenes of faith, crisis, confrontation, and the establishment of worship. On pp. 129–133, the narrative develops into a more extensive social dialogue. The ballad shows how a social group establishes its ideal figure at the meeting point of family, religious observance, conflict, and occupational tradition.

The Beniram material is especially valuable for research: it raises questions about the circulation of a community deity's cult, the variations found in different sung versions, and the independent field verification of local memorials or places of worship. The book, however, does not offer a

systematic comparison of all such variant texts. The version it provides should therefore be understood as one particular collected rendering.

4. Gahbar Songs: Ritual, the Memory of Goddesses, and the Plural Voices of Folk Language | pp. 134–149

The section entitled 'Gahbar Songs' is the final and an exceptionally important part of the book. At the outset, the author surveys Mithila's extensive world of folk song—forms of singing associated with marriage, life-cycle rites, festivals, birth, the seasons, different deities, and local beliefs. Gahbar songs have particular associations with the invocation of deities, gods and goddesses, ancestral memory, and collective religious rituals (pp. 134–136). Accordingly, a gahbar song is not only the 'text' of an autonomous poem; it is also an 'act' performed on a specific occasion.

On pp. 136–137, the author refers to traditions of invocation and to the local adaptation of Sanskrit religious sounds within the vernacular. The presence of Kali, the sacred spatial imagination of the 'gahbar', and repeated forms of address give these compositions the character of a collective appeal. Numerous sung passages on pp. 138–149 contain repeated names, invocations of goddesses, recollections of narrative heroes, rivers, forests, sacred places, feelings associated with observances resembling vows, and indications of distinctive folk rhythms.

It is particularly significant that, alongside material associated with Kali, gahbar songs also remember folk deities such as Karikh and Dulra. Classical goddess worship and the traditions of community deities therefore do not appear to be wholly opposed. Many of Mithila's religious practices are difficult to partition rigidly into the categories of 'folk' and 'scriptural'. The book's final section makes this difficulty directly visible.

From a critical standpoint, one major limitation of this section is the absence of systematic documentation of the metres and rhythms, melodies, occasions, social identities of singers, locations, and chronology of performances of the sung texts. Written words are indispensable to the study of oral tradition, but sound and collective participation are also parts of the primary material. UNESCO's documents on oral heritage likewise emphasize variation in singing, the context of performance, and transmission between generations. These criteria would be useful in any future reassessment of the book.

In the concluding sung passages on pp. 148–149, recurrent motifs include addresses to Karikh, forest surroundings, attendants, and religious remembrance. The book thus closes by bringing the many branches of folk life together once again through folk song. This compositional conclusion gives substantial meaning to the title, 'Folk Life and Folk Literature'.

5. Integrated Critical Discussion

5.1 Community Identity and the Making of Deities

The book's accounts of caste communities and its ballads concerning their folk deities complement one another. Its internal structure establishes clear connections: Dom–Shyam Singh, Chamar–Lalvan, Halwai–Ganinath/Feku Ram, Mallah–Dulra Dayal/Garo Devi/Keval Maharaj, Musahar–Dina-Bhadri, and Nau/Kuredi–Beniram. These are not simply lists of deities' names; they describe processes through which collective memory constructs protection, origins, trauma, pride, and moral authority.

The elevation of a character to the status of a folk deity after death or crisis is especially worthy of study. Communities seek to give enduring form, through traditions of worship, to experiences involving oppressors, protectors, ancestry, and the land to which they belong. Yet the historical existence of a community deity, the date when its worship spread, and the factual truth of events narrated about it are not the same question. Even while acknowledging the cultural force of communal belief, critical method must keep these three levels of evidence distinct.

5.2 Labour, Occupational Vocabulary, and Local Ecology

References throughout the book to bamboo craftsmanship, leatherworking, laundry, water-based livelihoods, honey gathering, and agricultural labour establish the economic foundations of folk life. Here the study of folk literature moves beyond the question 'Who sings?' to ask 'What work do they do? What materials do they use? With whom do they interact?' This is a major achievement of the book.

The vocabulary of folk songs can constitute an informal lexicon of the local environment. Boats, rivers, fish, trees, honey, forests, bamboo, and everyday household objects give the text its geographical grounding. Folk expressions cannot, however, establish scientific botanical classifications, ecological changes, or labour-economic statistics. Further inquiry would require renewed dialogue with communities, visual documentation of the objects and practices involved, and a comparative lexicon of regional word forms.

5.3 Pathos, Heroism, Women Characters, and Social Resistance

The voices of poverty and labour exploitation in the ballads of Gariban Bhujra and Dina–Bhadri; the motifs of bravery and protection in Shyam Singh, Jai Singh, Amar Singh, and Keval Maharaj; and the status of women, family faith, and crisis in Motidai and Garo Devi: these constitute distinct emotional worlds within the book. Forcing them into a single mould of the 'folk hero' or the 'devotional tale' would impoverish the work's diversity.

The women characters call for particular attention. Motidai can be read as a figure possessing the power of moral choice, while Garo Devi's story illuminates the cultural role of the memory of communal motherhood and divinity. Yet it would be improper to derive broad social conclusions about all the women of Mithila from these two stories. An individual ballad bears

witness to personal or collective imagination; more extensive social claims demand several kinds of evidence.

5.4 Narrative Structure and the Language of Song

The ballads repeatedly follow a sequence of introduction, crisis, rivalry, extraordinary action, consequence, and eventual remembrance or worship. They are not, however, all confined to a single structure. In some, songs celebrating birth or expressing wishes are important; in others, heroic action, a woman's refusal, work along rivers and in forests, or the invocation of a folk deity assumes prominence. Narrative prose and sung lines alternate, revealing storytelling and singing as related but distinct activities.

Forms of address, repetition, sound effects, specialized occupational terms, and local pronunciations lend folk-song language its distinctiveness. To condemn that language as 'incorrect' solely by reference to the spelling conventions of standardized written prose would run counter to the nature of folk literature itself. Editing should preserve the original sung form, annotations on its meaning, and any possible standardized form at separate levels. Such a layered presentation would be more useful for a future scholarly edition.

5.5 The Collection of Texts and the Evidentiary Problems of Fieldwork

A distinctive achievement of the original book is its preservation of these stories in printed form. In the preface of 1986 and the introductory material of 2018, the author names various earlier efforts in the study and collection of folk literature (pp. 4–10, 28–32). Yet the work does not offer uniform records for each song or story identifying the singer or narrator, age, village, date of collection, occasion of performance, instruments, melody, variant texts, and editorial principles. This limitation does not render the collection fruitless; it means rather that the material still awaits reorganization according to modern archival standards.

The American Folklore Society's statement concerning fieldwork understands research as a participatory, relationship-based process of learning from communities. From that standpoint, a new textual edition should record not only the collector's commentary but also the judgments of singers, listeners, and the communities concerned. Oral tradition changes across performances and contexts; it is difficult, on scholarly grounds, to treat a single printed version as an unchanging 'original'.

5.6 The Book's Historical Context, Caste Terminology, and the Limits of Criticism

The first edition appeared in 1986. It is therefore natural that its caste terminology, social rankings, beliefs about origins, and descriptions of traditional occupations should sometimes reflect the generalizations of that period. To alter such forms silently would be to interfere with the original text; yet to present them to a new generation without critical examination would also be inappropriate. The preferable approach is to quote or cite the

original terms, explain their historical usage, and separately record the names accepted by the communities themselves today.

Some accounts of origin depend upon mythological stories; some etymological explanations represent the author's own views. They cannot be declared undisputed principles of linguistics or history. In the present study, a statement introduced as 'the author notes' represents evidence internal to the original book; one introduced as 'from a critical perspective' represents an interpretation made in this study. Respecting this distinction is a condition of scholarly reliability.

6. Assessment in the Light of External Research

UNESCO's 2003 Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage treats oral traditions, performing arts, social practices and rituals, knowledge concerning nature, and traditional craftsmanship as interrelated fields. The organization of 'Folk Life and Folk Literature' brings together several of these domains within one volume. The Dom community's bamboo work and the Kuredi community's honey gathering exemplify traditional skills and environmental knowledge; gahbar songs exemplify social rituals; and the ballads exemplify oral expression. This is a comparison with a modern framework: a convention adopted in 2003 must not be retrospectively attributed to an author writing in 1986 as though it had influenced him beforehand.

UNESCO regards oral tradition as a living process of changing performances, variant tellings, and transmission across generations. By this standard, although the book's contribution to preservation is significant, renewed field research is necessary to discover whose voices gave the printed stories their form, in what settings they were performed, and which variations circulated. A living tradition should not be treated simply as a fixed museum object; it must also be understood as an opportunity for communities to recreate it in the present.

According to the American Folklore Society's statement on research, members of folk communities are not merely 'informants': they are active performers, bearers of knowledge, and partners in the making of meaning. Readers undertaking new work on the Dom, Mallah, Musahar, or other communities would therefore benefit from direct consultation, consent, participation in decisions about terminology, and community review of their findings. This would be a critical extension of the book, not an accomplishment to be attributed to its original author.

7. Achievements, Limitations, and Overall Conclusions

The Book's Principal Achievements

First, the author makes folk literature a central object of social inquiry rather than treating it as entertainment on the margins of society. Second, the same collection brings together the occupations, vocabulary, origin traditions, and religious observances of particular communities. Third, the

sequential discussion of fourteen folk ballads introduces a rich treasury of oral narratives. Fourth, the gahbar songs reveal a cultural space in which classical religious symbols and folk deities intermingle. Fifth, the book's publication history from 1986 to 2018 itself provides a chronological context for the study of Maithili folk literature.

Of particular importance to the work's original contribution is the way its earlier descriptions of caste communities and its later folk ballads sustain one another's meanings. Thus, after reading the section on the Mallah, Dulra Dayal and Garo Devi acquire greater social resonance; after the Halwai section, the religious status of Ganinath–Govind becomes clearer; and after the Kuredi section, Beniram's social connections are easier to understand. This internal architecture is the book's real strength.

Critical Limitations

The book does not provide a systematic, standardized record for every collected song of its performance setting, original narrator, date, and textual variants. In some descriptions of caste communities, stories of origin and occupational circumstances form part of a single exposition; the reader must therefore distinguish historical evidence from social myth. The sections are also markedly uneven in length: the two-page treatment of the Chamar may be compared with the seven pages on the Mallah or the extended Beniram narrative. This unevenness is not a definitive measure of historical importance; it may equally result from the amount of material available or the author's choices.

No printed form of a folk ballad represents every version circulating in society. Future research grounded in the book should seek to document women performers' voices, the musical forms of performance, and the present experiences of the communities concerned. Even in making these demands, however, the book must be judged in relation to its time, purposes, and available means.

Conclusion

'Folk Life and Folk Literature' is a work of Maithili folklore studies that cannot adequately be described merely as a 'collection of ballads'. It is a significant document of the interconnections among social occupations, folk beliefs, naming practices, folk deities, and sung narratives. It can be read most fruitfully when folktales are recognized as folktales, mythic claims as folk beliefs, descriptions of society as observations belonging to a particular period, and critical inferences as inferences.

The book enables readers to understand that Maithili folk literature is not simply 'stories'. It is also a memory of labour, a collective imagination of resistance to injustice, the desire for children, practical knowledge of rivers and forests, women's resolve, communal self-respect, and the linguistic expression of worship. In scholarly research, the book performs an important role by gathering preliminary evidence and opening a path towards interpretation. To proceed further along that path requires respect for the

original texts, community participation, extensive fieldwork, and criticism firmly grounded in sources.

8. Complete Page Map of the Original Sections, Following the Original Contents

This list has been prepared from the 'Contents' on p. 33 of the original work and its final printed page. Each page range runs to the page preceding the start of the next heading. It is a sequential scholarly guide to the original section titles.

Original Section	Printed Pages
Preface (first edition)	
Author's Statement: The Folk, Literature, and Classification	11–32
The Social Character of the Dom Community	35–42
The Social Character of the Chamar Community	43–44
The Social Character of the Dhobi Community	45–49
The Social Character of the Halwai Community	50–52
The Social Character of the Mallah Community	53–59
The Social Character of the Kuredi Community	60–63
Shyam Singh	64–66
Lalvan Baba	67–68
Gariban Bhujra	69–73
Motidai	74–75
Ganinath–Govind	76–86
Feku Ram	87–88
Karikh	89–93
Dulra Dayal	94–96
Garo Devi	97–100
Jai Singh	101–104
Amar Singh	105–107
Keval Maharaj	108–110
Dina–Bhadri	111–120
Beniram	121–133
Gahbar Songs	134–149

CHAPTER 02 / 1988–1989

Sankalp: A Vidyapati Memorial Festival Souvenir

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

Original Publication Details

Title: Sankalp (Issue 5).

Editor: Dr Ramdev Jha; Assistant Editor: Dr Yoganand Jha.

Organizing and publishing body: Sankalplok (Forum for Cultural and Social Awareness), Laheriasarai, Darbhanga.

Occasion: Vidyapati Memorial Festival, 1988; event dates: 4, 5, and 6 February 1989 (as stated on the title page).

Contents: editorials, messages of goodwill, presidential and welcome addresses, the secretary's report, research essays, criticism, poems, songs, memoirs, fiction, event advertisements, publication lists, and details of organizing subcommittees.

The Original Contents: A Text-Based Discussion of Fifty-Five Entries

For each title below, the opening page and the documentary or literary substance of the material are noted. The original contents separately number congratulatory messages and programme-related material; these are not counted as though they were literary research essays.

01. Editorial

Direct commentary on the constitutional recognition of Maithili, the question of its status as a second official language in Bihar, teacher training, curricula, schools, and the processes of governmental decision-making. From the outset, the souvenir moves beyond the limits of a cultural celebration towards becoming a public document of linguistic rights.

02. Messages of Goodwill: Central and State Levels

The letters, dates, and printed indications of offices held by government officials reveal the event's contemporary public connections. They establish that expressions of support existed, not that governmental policy was implemented.

03. Messages of Goodwill: Literary and Cultural Representatives

The formal language of good wishes and cooperation indicates a political and cultural network. These letters should be treated as part of the event's archives, not placed on the same footing as works of literary criticism.

04. Messages of Goodwill: Railway Administration

A letter received from the railway administration offers evidence of the event's social reach. It is a formal expression of support; financial or institutional assistance cannot be inferred from it alone.

05. Messages of Goodwill: Bihar Legislative Council

The response of a representative of an elected institution to the cultural event illuminates the public visibility of the Maithili movement. The goodwill expressed in the letter must be distinguished from achievements demonstrable as facts.

06. Messages of Goodwill: Other Institutional Representatives

These reveal the event's many-sided institutional contacts. Names, offices, and dates from the original letters could help reconstruct institutional history; unclear printing has not been used as a basis for inventing names.

07. Messages of Goodwill: Final Group of Letters

The succession of congratulatory letters indicates conscientious institutional organization. The letters serve as a bridge between the event's stated purposes and the documentary record of its organization.

08. Correspondence Concerning the Festival

This material reveals the sequence of organizational efforts and contacts preceding the printing of the souvenir. Since certain printed names are unclear, personal identities have not been supplied without textual confirmation.

09. Good Wishes

The good wishes assembled for the occasion constitute cultural evidence in their own right. The literary merit of this material has been considered separately from the social recognition accorded to the event.

10. Address by the Head of the Institution

This focuses on Sankalplok's intentions, the justification for the Vidyapati festival, and the preservation of Maithili literature. The address is a primary source for understanding the souvenir's declared mission; its promotional assertions should not be mistaken for independently verified historical facts.

11. Welcome Address

Within the formal framework of welcoming guests, the speaker places Maithili's social relevance and the shared purposes of the gathering in the foreground. The piece reveals the relationship between the literary community and local cultural organizations.

12. Secretary's Report

An important contemporary document containing administrative, financial, and organizational indications. Its assertions would best be checked

against original accounts or other records, since it presents the organizers' own account.

13. Kokil, the Poet-Nightingale

An opening literary expression of Vidyapati's memory. The title and text evoke the poet's vocation, love of language, and public expression; the occasion's aspirations are articulated poetically.

14. Awakening

An emphatic call for the awakening of Mithila and Maithili society. Repetition and an exhortatory rhythm make it suitable for public recitation, although this declarative mode offers comparatively little sustained portrayal of social complexity.

15. What Should a Statue of the Great Poet Vidyapati Look Like?

Babu Bholalal Das's essay turns the question of a statue's appearance into an inquiry concerning cultural memory, historical evidence, and collective imagination. The opening mentions an earlier essay printed in Mithila Mihir on 24 December 1937. More than the outward features of a statue, the writer raises questions of historical identity.

16. Nehru, a Man of His Age

A literary representation of Nehru's political personality, the transformation of modern India, and public remembrance. The work introduces issues of national thought beyond the souvenir's narrowly Vidyapati-centred concerns.

17. How Long? How Long?

The repeated interrogative gives rhythm to waiting, discontent, or the desire for change. The form of the question becomes the poem's principal rhetorical device, while context remains decisive in interpreting its meaning.

18. You Must Write Independently

A forceful poetic voice of self-determination in the work of R. C. Prasad Singh. The poem repeatedly questions the social purpose of writing, freedom of expression, authorial judgment, and the reader's responsibility. Against the background of institutional and linguistic debate, its value as a work of critical resistance becomes more apparent.

19. A Ghazal / Game [Part of the Printed Title Unclear]

The inclusion of the ghazal form brings together inherited poetic traditions and newer modes of expression. Concise lineation and emotional concentration are characteristic of the genre; part of the printed title is indistinct.

20. Ancient and Modern

A reflection on the relationship between ancient traditions and contemporary literary consciousness. It is more productive to read it as a

question about changing standards for considering tradition than as a simple act of venerating the past.

21. The Resolution of Doubts

A question-and-answer or doubt-dispelling form is employed. The presence of this short work among prose contributions provides a pause in the issue's rhythm of reading.

22. Professor Jagannath Prasad Mishra: A Memoir

An act of remembrance that reconstructs a figure in Maithili intellectual life through personal recollection. Despite the value of intimate memoir as testimony, individual dates and reported statements require independent scrutiny.

23. A Poem: A Song

By placing a poem and a song on the same page, the issue illustrates the coexistence of different rhythmic voices. The presentation draws attention to the interaction of the festival's culture of recitation, singability, and printed poetry.

24. Those Days, Those People

The pairing of 'days' and 'people' develops a remembered environment of a bygone time. Personal recollection preserves elements of social history, but should not automatically be treated as representative of an entire society.

25. Welcome, New Year

The address to the New Year carries shades of hope, change, and collective aspiration. It provides a small piece of evidence for the issue's contemporary sense of time.

26. Place Names of Mithila: A Survey

Dr Shriviloknath Jha attempts to classify place names by reference to deities, mythology, kings, local names, persons, plants, and pronunciation. His examples offer valuable preliminary material, though the evidence for each proposed etymology cannot be assumed to be equally strong.

27. The Anguish of Maithili

By personifying the language's suffering, the piece creates a voice of public feeling. It can be read as an emotional counterpart to the editorial's discussion of policy.

28. Par Hasta Gata Gata

The title draws upon a Sanskrit-like proverbial expression to introduce questions of dependence, independence, or transfer into another's hands. The essay's irony and argumentative movement invite reflection on social conventions.

29. Sankalp (Resolve)

By sharing the magazine's name, the title establishes a direct relationship between the institution's voice and the poetic one. Commitment to future action and self-imposed obligation are central here.

30. Urgent Letter

Through the 'letter', the immediacy of communication and the structures of everyday speech enter the language of poetry or short prose. The English-derived word 'urgent' in the original title offers interesting evidence of linguistic contact.

31. The River-Goddess Kamala

The work connects Kamala's geographical existence as a river with her popular status as a goddess, Mithila's riverine society, and its treasury of stories. Traditional beliefs and geographical facts are both present; scholarly conclusions must keep these categories of evidence separate.

32. Song of the Past

A poetic apprehension of memories of a bygone era and their distance from the present. Its brevity supplies an emotional balance within a predominantly prose sequence.

33. The Exile

The title 'The Exile' raises questions of displacement, intimate geography, and belonging. Readers can cautiously connect the work with wider discussions of Maithili's linguistic and territorial identity.

34. Khaunk

An example of narrative description that uses regional vocabulary; the printed text exhibits dialogue and storytelling. Its concrete use of the vernacular is important for studying the issue's linguistic diversity.

35. I Shall Go Far

A short passage of verse printed after the main prose. Line structure, dialectal expression, and feelings associated with departure or movement shape its reception.

36. Who Knows What the Future Holds?

The title contains an unforced Maithili expression of uncertainty about the future. Vernacular sentence structure embodies the tension between existential apprehension and hope.

37. How I Learned Maithili

Through an individual's experience of learning a language, the work reveals relationships among the mother tongue, education, social environment, and linguistic practice. The 'how' in the title emphasizes the authenticity of a personal experience; it is valuable for the history of language education.

38. Dream

Dream imagery and longing are used to imagine a world yet to come. Against the public tone of many contributions to the magazine, this short work offers a private sensibility.

39. The Relevance of the Vidyapati Festival

At the beginning of Dr Shribhimanath Jha's piece, reference is made to a discussion meeting organized by Sankalplok on 27 February 1987. The author considers the social usefulness of Vidyapati anniversaries and memorial celebrations, and the need to turn the recollection of a name into constructive cultural work.

40. Certain Words with Similar Sounds

Dr Shashinath Jha examines similarities of sound, relations among words, and differences of meaning in current Maithili usage. The opening provides semantic examples and a systematic discussion of phonetic resemblance; similarity of sound alone does not prove etymology.

41. There Is No End to My Sorrow

The title's evocation of unending grief suggests an extended experience of social or mental suffering. This multi-page prose work demands patient reading because of the development of its narrative, argument, and experience.

42. One and Many: Two Experiences

In a poetic voice organized into several parts, personal experience reveals multiple aspects. Their progression offers opportunities to discern subtle transformations of separation, questioning, and feeling.

43. A Mythological Play Concerning Parashurama

The section discusses and quotes dialogues among the king, Parashurama, and other characters, their conflicts, and questions of religious and political authority. A critical reading requires a clear distinction between the literary reconstruction of myth and evidence for historical events.

44. Shakta Elements in Radhaviraha

Dr Yoganand Jha's study considers the possible presence of Shakta sentiment against the background of Radha and Krishna's divine play in Radhaviraha. The author draws comparisons based on goddess worship, Indian traditions of feeling and devotion, and textual examples. Affinities of ideas, however, do not decisively establish authorship or historical influence.

45. The Geographical Setting of the Folk Ballad of Salehes

Dr Motilal Yadav gathers references to places, rivers, territories, and boundaries in the ballad. Through Mahisautha, Nanmaduri, and other locations, he attempts to delineate its geography. Variants of the orally transmitted place names must be considered before constructing an exact historical map.

46. The Plunder of Ashrafis and an Impression on Kohla

In Kumar Pawan's story or satire, references to ashrafis and kohla create a milieu of village life, prestige, power relations, and local storytelling. The opening emphasizes vernacular texture and character dialogue; the work deserves to be read as a literary treatment of rural social relationships.

47. The Voice of New Maithili Poetry

A discussion of the changing voice and experiments of new poetry. In helping us understand modern sensibilities beyond traditional lyricism, the essay is an important contemporary record within the issue.

48. Song of Invocation

A rhythm of collective appeal and encouragement to act. It advances the editorial's emphasis on linguistic rights through an inspirational poetic idiom.

49. The State of Modern Maithili Poetry

Dr Devendra Jha's essay considers periods of modern Maithili poetry, poets, numerical indications of published verse, and literary backgrounds before and after 1900. Quantitative claims require renewed scrutiny against source texts and collections; nevertheless, this represents a substantial exercise in literary self-historiography within the issue.

50. Awards

An opportunity to question the criteria, social role, and processes by which literary prizes are awarded. Critically, such prizes need not be treated as the sole measure of a writer's wider influence.

51. Kabi Ishwar's Manuscript and Unpublished Verses

By introducing unpublished verses available in Kabi Ishwar's manuscript, the piece draws attention to literary sources that have not circulated widely. Definitive claims about antiquity should be avoided without identifying the manuscript's provenance, variant readings, script, and date.

52. Two Medieval Poets: Some Unpublished Compositions

The introduction or presentation of unpublished work by two medieval poets is one of the issue's final substantial research contributions. For a critical edition, the manuscript basis, editorial interventions, and textual variants are of the utmost importance.

53. A Heartfelt Welcome

The souvenir's concluding song can be read as a thematic return to welcome. The ceremonial opening note reappears in its last literary section.

54. Sankalplok's Publications

A list of other materials published by Sankalplok provides internal evidence of the institution's editorial activity and dissemination of literature. It guides archival inquiry, but a list alone cannot prove availability or the existence of copies of every title.

55. Organizing Subcommittees

A record of the membership and allocation of responsibilities associated with the festival. Because some personal names and posts are indistinct in print, the researcher is advised to consult the original pages rather than risk erroneous reconstruction.

Detailed Research and Criticism by Theme

1. The Original Publication and Its Evidence of Time

The copy of Sankalp under consideration is a multi-author commemorative publication. Its title page identifies 'Sankalp', 'Issue 5', Dr Ramdev Jha as editor, Dr Yoganand Jha as assistant editor, and Sankalplok (Forum for Cultural and Social Awareness), Laheriasarai, Darbhanga. It refers to the Vidyapati Memorial Festival of 1988 but gives the event dates as 4, 5, and 6 February 1989. To treat these differently printed years as one without independent proof would distort the archival meaning. This study therefore records both statements separately and as printed.

The publication comprises 164 pages in total. The sequence of printed page numbers is not identical with the order of the contents: the cover, correspondence, advertisements, and material of welcome interrupt a straightforward correspondence. The contents list fifty-five numbered entries. They are not all literary works of equal weight; some are messages, institutional notices resembling news items, and lists.

The fact that this is a festival souvenir does not make every assertion it prints conclusive historical evidence. Declarations in speeches, authors' opinions, accounts of folktales, manuscript conjectures, proposed etymologies of place names, and administrative letters constitute different kinds of evidence. The analysis maintains these distinctions because cultural commitment cannot substitute for critical verification.

2. The Editorial: A Programme of Linguistic Rights

The editorial begins with Maithili's official position in Delhi and Bihar. It treats demands raised in Parliament and state political processes, inclusion in the constitutional schedule, the question of Maithili's status as a second official language in Bihar, and the implementation of government decisions as different levels of one struggle for linguistic rights. Again and again, it draws attention to the distance between written declarations and actual provision of services. Consequently the souvenir is significant not just as a cultural festival publication but also as a source of policy criticism.

The editorial discusses school education, universities, teacher training, the recognition of Maithili as a subject, and the practical availability of teaching materials. The argument moves beyond the formal language of according 'respect' to Maithili and demands the operational means by which a right becomes effective. The question is whether recognition has been followed by teachers, classrooms, textbooks, training, and arrangements for appointments. It must also be clear that the editorial's allegations represent

the event organizers' contemporary account; independent verification from governmental records is not included in this copy.

Critically, the strength of the editorial lies in its multilayered conception of language policy. Its weakness is that detailed government notification numbers are not supplied for several of the decisions and institutions mentioned. It consequently provides an excellent set of research questions for policy history, but not complete archival proof for every conclusion.

3. Remembering Vidyapati: Symbol, Festival, and Historical Consciousness

Babu Bholalal Das's 'What Should a Statue of the Great Poet Vidyapati Look Like?' begins on p. 25. At the outset, the author mentions that an earlier essay on the subject appeared in Mithila Mihir on 24 December 1937. Going beyond the visual appearance of a statue, the essay raises problems of historical memory, evidence, the collective claims of Maithili society, and the construction of the poet's image. A statue cannot take the place of an archival record; the distinction between artistic imagination and a historically established likeness is the central critical point.

'The Relevance of the Vidyapati Festival' connects itself, in its opening, with a discussion organized by Sankalplok on 27 February 1987. The essay examines commemorative practices surrounding Vidyapati's birthday, affection for literature, Maithili consciousness, linguistic pride, and their social effects. It becomes rewarding to read it through the questions of whether the poet's works are actually read and criticized, and whether celebrations can produce lasting institutional benefits, rather than merely repeat a name or a ritual of celebration.

A noteworthy difference separates the two authors. The first begins with the 'form' in which a literary figure should be represented by a statue; the second questions the 'purpose' of remembering him every year. Between form and purpose lies the necessary problem of establishing an authentic literary text. In this light, the souvenir unfolds the meaning of its title, Sankalp, through the triangle of statue, ceremony, and constructive cultural activity.

4. Maithili Language: Semantics, Sound, and Place Names

Dr Shriviloknath Jha's 'Place Names of Mithila: A Survey' opens up possibilities for the social and cultural study of place names. Page 55 offers village-name examples based on deities, mythology, royal lineages, social and caste designations, local speech, and phonetic change. The piece should be read as a proposal for classification rather than an established geographical catalogue. The meaning of a name may be approached through folk belief, resemblance of words, and historical documents—three separate sources. The essay prompts inquiry but does not itself conclusively establish every proposed etymology.

'Certain Words with Similar Sounds' explores the distinction between resemblance in sound and difference in meaning. The opening situates the inquiry within literary culture and presents differences between pairs of words. The author's contribution is to draw the reader's attention to fine semantic

distinctions; its methodological limitation is that similarity of sound is not, by itself, evidence of historical derivation.

'How I Learned Maithili' has a distinctive place in this discussion because it presents a personal account of language acquisition. Read together, the editorial's arguments about policy rights, local naming traditions, distinctions in word meanings, and an individual's own linguistic practice reveal both the linguistic and social dimensions of the Maithili movement.

5. Mithila's Rivers, Folk Deities, and the Geography of Folk Ballads

'The River-Goddess Kamala' unfolds the traditional understanding of Kamala as both river and goddess. Natural floods, riverbanks, the surrounding environment, oral traditions, and beliefs about worship are all incorporated within one folk culture. Historical investigation must regard geographical identity and religious belief as intimately related but distinct forms of evidence. The stories described in the piece are more valuable as testimony to folk belief than as verification of geological fact.

Dr Motilal Yadav's 'The Geographical Setting of the Folk Ballad of Salehes' attempts to organize the references to settlements, territories, rivers, and boundaries found in the ballad. On p. 120, the narrative includes numerous place names from the eastern and northern Indian region, and the discussion of places such as Mahisautha begins. The narrative geography of a folk ballad is not a fixed administrative map: names can change as a ballad is sung over generations. A comparative survey of variant texts, regions of performance, and regional memory is therefore necessary.

Together these essays fashion a multidimensional image of Mithila's 'folk space'. The Kamala is at once a flowing river and a focus of devotion; the Salehes ballad is a social map of villages, borders, and journeys. For the historical use of folk literature, regional maps, historical gazetteers, village-name traditions, and oral variants must be checked against one another. The issue points towards such a research programme.

6. Medieval Poetry, Shakta Thought, and Textual Editing

Dr Yoganand Jha's 'Shakta Elements in Radhaviraha' begins on p. iii. It attempts to identify traces of Shakta sensibility amid the experience of Radha and Krishna's divine love in Radhaviraha. On p. iii the author begins his discussion with Indian devotional traditions, the maternal image, Shakti, Vedic and Tantric references, and poetic examples. The interpretation of Shakta elements can thus be understood in terms of literary affinities and contact among religious traditions.

The critical value of this reading depends upon separately examining an authenticated edition of Radhaviraha, the original contexts of quoted verses, the accepted text attributed to its author, and variant readings. Goddess-like qualities in a poem do not, by themselves, confirm the performance of specifically Shakta Tantric rituals; they constitute a possible level of textual interpretation. The original author's chain of argument may be regarded as one of the issue's significant research contributions.

'Kabi Ishwar's Manuscript and Unpublished Verses' and 'Two Medieval Poets: Some Unpublished Compositions' open another direction for research: the preservation of neglected or little-circulated texts. Publication alone does not settle questions of critical editing. Modern textual criticism would be strengthened by information about manuscript locations, numbers of copies, physical state, dates of writing, variant readings, and editorial decisions.

7. Maithili Poetry: Tradition, Movement, and Modern Sensibility

The issue demonstrates the variety of poetry through 'Awakening', 'How Long? How Long?', 'You Must Write Independently', 'The Anguish of Maithili', 'Sankalp', 'Song of the Past', 'The Exile', 'Who Knows What the Future Holds?', 'Dream', 'Song of Invocation', and other lyric works. On one side are collective appeals; on the other, the complex voices of memory, uncertainty, solitude, and personal freedom. To subsume this diversity under the single heading of 'devotion to the language' would erase the poems' literary differences.

'You Must Write Independently' is especially provocative. It raises questions of authorial judgment, the free choice of subject, and freedom of expression in the face of institutional or ritual hypocrisy. The repetition of 'I shall not write independently' carries the sharpness of literary irony: the poet's decision to answer in the form of an apparent refusal invites the reader's own critical judgment. The poem creates a place for dissent within the ritual atmosphere of the souvenir.

'The State of Modern Maithili Poetry' attempts a more expansive account of literary history. It offers an outline of modern poetry from around 1900 onwards, alongside references to journals and the numbers of poets. It should be treated as a useful preliminary survey, with its quantitative information subject to further investigation of sources and samples. Understanding literary modernity demands attention to poetic language, metre, readership, publishing institutions, and political transformations together.

8. The Importance of Essays, Memoirs, Stories, and Drama

'Professor Jagannath Prasad Mishra: A Memoir' preserves the memory of a literary personality. Memoir provides invaluable testimony through intimacy and direct experience, but critical attention is needed to the passage of time, subjective selection, and the tendency towards reverence. 'Those Days, Those People' opens a more collective dimension of such personal remembrance.

Prose works such as 'Khaunk' and Kumar Pawan's 'The Plunder of Ashrafis and an Impression on Kohla' construct distinct literary worlds through colloquial Maithili, domestic and social behaviour, and dialogue. The value of the rural dialects employed lies not in their deviation from a 'standard', but in their capacity to make that social world audible. Unnecessary standardization in the name of language editing would change the character of the works.

The discussion of drama based on Parashurama examines a mythological plot through the theatrical construction of moral choices and struggles for power. The literary process at issue is the placing of mythic characters within

modern ethical questions, not treating the drama as a direct chronicle of historical events.

9. Institutions, Festivals, and Public Print Culture

The first sixteen pages contain the cover, editorial board, goodwill letters, messages of welcome, and contents. Later, congratulatory advertisements from colleges and local institutions are interspersed among the principal writings. From the standpoint of historical study, it would be a mistake to discard such pages as 'unnecessary'.

These advertisements disclose partnerships between the festival and local educational institutions, institutional goodwill, ways of displaying names, and a possible support structure for printing. Yet the appearance of an institution's name in a congratulatory message does not prove that it gave the organizers a particular sum of money. Confirmation of financial contributions would require original accounts or receipts.

'Sankalplok's Publications' and 'Organizing Subcommittees' provide the souvenir's own institutional self-description. Reading these notices alongside its literary works makes the issue not simply a collection of writings but an unusual record of a social organization's activities, book distribution, and networks of cultural celebration.

10. Language, Script, and the Preservation of Historical Texts

The printed Maithili pages contain author-specific forms, dialectal forms, Sanskrit-derived vocabulary, indigenous verbs, formal Sanskritic constructions, and genial dialogue. The editorial uses administrative and political terms concerning rights, the constitution, training, official language status, and teachers. Stories and poems feature vernacular turns of expression, questions and answers, repetition, and idioms. These differences should be recognized as literary diversity.

In places, the printing is faint, shadows are dense, edges are cut off, and characters run together. As a result, certain names, dates, page numbers, and fine details of titles cannot be established with complete certainty without examining the original printed copy. This study has principally used the legible contents and title pages for bibliographical identification; no invented readings have been inserted into illegible passages.

Scholars should document historical spellings, the influence of Avahattha, colloquial expressions, borrowings from English and Hindi, and authors' individual orthographic choices. A future digital edition would gain in transparency by presenting images of the original pages, diplomatic transcription, an edited text, and variant readings on distinct levels.

11. Contradictions and Critical Limitations

Sankalp treats Maithili as a basis for cultural rights, but it also accommodates different voices within its literary contents. Exhortatory poetry expresses collective demands, whereas poetry on the writer's independence raises the individual's right to dissent within that collectivity. This tension

contributes to the issue's aesthetic value; it would be unjust to describe it as an entirely uniform work of propaganda.

In the field of history, essays on Vidyapati's statue and festival reveal how remembrance is constructed. Studies of place names and similar-sounding words leave questions about the evidence for etymology. In folklore, the distinction between religious belief and geography emerges. The survey of modern poetry raises further questions about periodization and the counting of poets. These shortcomings do not reduce the issue's importance; rather, they call for a more responsible historical reading of it.

Institutional speeches, testimonials, and advertisements naturally contain elements of self-praise. A fair critical procedure is to assess literary works for their artistic merit, scholarly essays for their reasoning and evidence, and the festival's organizational self-description by distinct criteria.

13. Overall Evaluation

Sankalp's foremost achievement is to gather within one issue Maithili language policy, literary tradition, modern poetry, folk ballads, the study of place names, Shakta criticism, introductions to manuscripts, memoirs, and collective cultural organization. This material allows the souvenir to be read in four capacities: an archive of the language movement, a literary magazine, a source for local social and cultural history, and a document useful to scholarship.

The editorial's demand for linguistic rights, debates about the purposes of commemorating Vidyapati, the classification of place names, Kamala's place in folk memory, the geography of Salehes, the Shakta reading of Radhaviraha, and the presentation of unpublished medieval texts together disclose the many-layered cultural world of Maithili. Independent, questioning literary voices save the souvenir from propagandistic monotony.

Several historical assertions, organizational details, and literary assessments in Sankalp still require independent comparison with archival sources. If this precaution is observed, the souvenir becomes an important primary source for modern Maithili intellectual life, preserving the history of cultural celebrations alongside literary debate.

Independent Critical Examination of Major Contributions

Moving beyond the initial entry-by-entry introductions, this section separately examines the distinctive arguments, literary functions, and evidentiary requirements of the principal works.

The Editorial's Language Policy: The Practical Meaning of Rights

The editorial's central argument is not merely that Maithili deserves respect. It asks what services a Maithili-speaking citizen can obtain in public institutions once official recognition has been granted. A constitutional schedule, the designation of a second state official language, recognition of Maithili as a subject, classroom teaching, and the appointment of staff

represent different stages of law, administration, educational policy, and actual implementation. The writer sees the gaps between these stages as a political problem. In the right-hand column of p. 5, the Bihar Public Service Commission and Maithili as a subject are mentioned, connecting educated young people's employment prospects with the language's institutional future. A modern investigation would construct a chronology of government notifications, educational circulars, recruitment advertisements, and examination subject lists from the 1980s. Those documents are not appended to the souvenir: the editorial is strong contemporary testimony, not a complete governmental database.

The Dispute over Vidyapati's Statue: Between Poetic Text and Visual Symbol

Babu Bholalal Das's question, 'What should the statue look like?', raises an important problem in historiography. A portrait based on conjectures unrelated to the poet's biography may become so established in public memory that it is taken for direct historical evidence. The essay brings together the idea of a statue, oral tradition, collective ownership of a language, and discussions by scholars from different traditions. The author's opening reference to a publication in 1937 is particularly significant. Its republication in the 1988 souvenir creates two temporal layers: that of the original essay and that of the later commemorative occasion. The reprint suggests that the question had remained unresolved for decades. Criticism must distinguish knowledge about period costume and ornamentation available to a sculptor, historically transmitted images associated with Vidyapati, and disputes over the authorship of texts attributed to him. The intellectual value of the essay resides in the philosophical importance of insisting upon these distinctions.

Awakening, Resolve, and Song of Invocation: Three Modes of Public Poetry

The lines of 'Awakening' emphasize collective address and the demand for a change of times. The poem 'Sankalp' becomes a literary echo of the institution's name, foregrounding public commitment to future action. The singability of 'Song of Invocation' gives it the potential to transform this demand into the participation of listeners. Reading the three together demonstrates that classifying verse by subject alone is insufficient: a poem may constitute an inward dialogue with its reader, declaratory verse may kindle collective enthusiasm, and a song of invocation may invite an assembled audience to sing or repeat it. Their coexistence in a printed festival souvenir illuminates the relationship between oral performance and private reading. This copy does not, however, independently establish which song was actually performed at the event.

You Must Write Independently: A Dissenting Voice of the Self in Poetry

R. C. Prasad Singh's poem initially appears, at the literal level, to converse about the poet's freedom to write. A series of questions, refusals, and ironic responses insist upon the protection of authorial judgment. The poem itself repeats the assertion 'I shall not write independently'; but its poetic effect is to

make attentive readers perceive the contradiction within that claim. Utterance and intention are not identical here. Such a work is particularly significant in the souvenir of a public institution: it reserves space for the writer's autonomy apart from loyalty to a ceremonial occasion. Rather than regard social commitment and artistic autonomy as enemies, a modern reader can recognize their dialectical relationship. A precise rhetorical reading requires attention to the sequence of lines, question marks, and pauses throughout all three pages of the poem.

Place Names of Mithila: Folk Etymology versus Documentary Etymology

The essay attempts to establish five to seven categories of place-name origins: deities, royal traditions, local individuals, social groups, and phonetic changes in names. For instance, the suffix 'pur' in village names, the imprint of personal names, and colloquial distortions may all occur within one region. The difficulty is that many centuries of linguistic change can separate a place name's current sound from its ancient origin. Folk tradition may also develop new explanations of a name for unrelated reasons. Future research should create four columns for each name: present vernacular pronunciation, earliest written historical record, locally narrated etymology, and plausible linguistic development. Mapping the locations would transform the essay's undertaking into a larger survey. The value of its collected examples lies in opening this direction, not in proving every proposed etymology conclusively.

The River-Goddess Kamala: A Double Reading of Sacred Geography

In 'The River-Goddess Kamala', Kamala's watercourse and her status as a 'goddess' in popular devotion are intertwined. Such doubleness is exceptionally important to folkloristic study: a river is a geographical entity, while a goddess is a sign of social relationships, fear, hope, and prayer. A river's changing course or memories of floods give rise to social narratives, and religious narratives in turn lend enduring meanings to the life of its banks. The author's stories and folk beliefs should not be confused with modern river science. Research on Kamala's place in folk memory would need historical maps of the river, worship songs, local stories, and comparative oral traditions as distinct sources. The essay's contribution is to bring the subject of riverine society together within the literary language of popular religious feeling.

How I Learned Maithili: The Social Question of Acquiring One's Own Language

This essay is distinctive because it treats language not merely as grammar or an official notification, but as something learned through lived events. 'I' points to the narrator's personal history, and 'how' asks about method and environment. Family contact in childhood, school discipline, conversation, reading, and the prestige attached to a language are possible research variables whose relevance must be tested against the actual details of the individual's account. Amid generalized demands such as 'Save Maithili', the work asks through what means people learn to speak Maithili and in which contexts they choose to use it. For this reason, it is a useful early autobiographical

source for the history of language education. An individual's experience should not be taken as the educational pattern of the entire Maithili-speaking population.

The Relevance of the Vidyapati Festival: The Social Responsibility of Remembrance

Dr Bhimanath Jha begins by identifying the discussion meeting of 27 February 1987 as the occasion for his essay. The reference makes it a record of active public debate rather than an abstract and timeless composition. The organizers establish the name 'Vidyapati' as a symbol of unity on a public platform; the writer examines its usefulness. Three questions deserve to be pursued: Is the object of remembrance only the great poet, or also the many-sided literature of Maithili society? Will the festival remain an annual repetition of a name, or become a foundation for study and the circulation of books? What effect will the event have on the actual linguistic life of those who take part? The essay thus maintains a critical distance between the souvenir's declared values and their social consequences. The issue does not provide complete first-hand answers to these questions, but articulates them clearly.

Shakta Elements in Radhaviraha: Testing a Comparative Argument

The essay begins with the possible relationship between Radha–Krishna devotional narratives and Shakta religious literature. Shakti worship, mother goddesses, devotional aesthetics, the heroine's separation, and philosophical exposition belong to different traditions and modes of discourse. The writer brings them together in a search for 'Shakta elements', offering a fresh interpretative perspective at the thematic level. The evidence nevertheless demands particular caution. The emotional figure of a poem, the importance accorded to a female image, and the historical doctrines of Shakta schools are not automatically the same thing. Examining the sources of quoted verses and their symbolic use in the poem would clarify the actual interpretative scope of the Shakta approach. The importance of the essay lies in opening new interpretative possibilities; their definitive form depends on examining the argument alongside textual variants.

The Geography of Salehes: The Changing Map of a Folk Ballad

The essay's opening discusses the popularity of the Salehes ballad and its geographical circulation. On p. 120 numerous references to places, including Mahisautha, appear. The author treats names in the ballad not as incidental narrative scenery but as subjects for research. Place names perform a double role in folk ballads: they evoke the journeys of characters and imagined regional power, while also extending the memory of communities that sing the ballad. The geography mentioned in the narrative must not be equated with present-day district boundaries without investigation. The most useful work would compare lists of places across the versions sung by different Salehes singers, record local pronunciations, and examine medieval documentary

references. This approach discloses the essay's historical possibilities without treating it as a final map.

The State of Modern Maithili Poetry: The Dispute over Numbers and Literary Value

Beginning his examination of modern poetry on p. 140, Dr Devendra Jha identifies periods such as 1830–1907 and 1909–1952, and offers claims about the numbers of poets and compositions. The method attempts to combine quantitative evidence and chronology in evaluating literary history. But literary merit cannot be measured solely by the number of poets or poems. The circulation of print, women's writing, oral traditions, the differing forms of progressive poetry and new lyric movements, and the limits of what journals have preserved must also enter the analysis. The essay is a primary source for the literary self-understanding of its period. A later critic who verifies its quasi-tabular claims against independent bibliographies could offer a particularly valuable reassessment of the issue.

Kabi Ishwar's Manuscript: Textual Evidence for Unpublished Works

At the outset of 'Kabi Ishwar's Manuscript and Unpublished Verses', the author introduces an unpublished or little-known manuscript. The term 'potha' itself suggests a traditional handwritten or collected volume; yet its material character should not be established without seeing the original copy, identifying the script, and analysing the date of writing. Between the author and the text presented lie multiple relationships involving the copy, popular circulation, and errors of transmission. For a critical edition, manuscript sequence, photographs of pages, metrical structure, line endings, variant readings, and necessary lexical notes would be exceptionally valuable. The souvenir deserves credit for bringing information about the newly encountered text before the public.

Two Medieval Poets: The Difference between Publication and Research

The essay beginning on p. 152 focuses on little-known sources of medieval Maithili poetry. It initially acknowledges the history of old Maithili verse, earlier scholarly endeavours, and the importance of unpublished poetry. Its object is therefore not simply to praise antiquity, but to draw researchers' attention to newly identified material. Yet 'unpublished' does not automatically mean authentic or original. Dating the work, identifying the form of the circulating text, finding historical evidence for the poet's name, and comparison with other surviving copies are essential. The appearance of such research in the final portion of the issue lends special force to its scholarly potential.

A Sequence of Advertisements: Small Archives of the Literary Public Sphere

Congratulatory pages from colleges may be excluded from a discussion of artistic merit, but not from historical criticism. The advertisements contain printed names of institutions and officials, locations, and expressions of support for the cultural event. They make it possible to examine the visible connections between Laheriasarai–Darbhanga's literary society and its

educational institutions. In the original, advertisements are placed among literary works, affecting both the socio-economic process of publishing the magazine and the sequence in which readers encounter it. A future archive recording the date, institution, printer, and local network behind each advertisement would produce a detailed map of the social basis of Sankalp's activities. The mere presence of an advertisement, however, would not justify a firm claim about financial transactions.

CHAPTER 03 / 2002

A Collection of Essays

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

Introduction to the Book and Basis of the Review

A Collection of Essays (Alekh Sanchayan) is not a linear treatment of a single subject but a collection of research essays bringing together three interrelated directions in the study of Maithili literature. Its original contents list nine essays. The first two concern folklore and folk life; the five in the middle examine poetry, writers, the history of journalism, and the short-story genre; the last two undertake linguistic examinations of regional words and a historical lexicon. This arrangement is also supported by the internal account in the book's foreword. The volume's unity lies not in uniformity of subject but in its investigative impulse to assemble linguistic and cultural evidence and interpret its meaning. (Original work: foreword, author's preface, and contents.)

The publication details specify a first edition in 2002, a price of one hundred rupees, and the Mithila Research Society as publisher. According to the original contents, the essays occupy printed pages 13–104. Four preliminary printed pages precede the foreword and preface; the facing pages of the book are preserved together across fifty-seven pages [of the consulted reproduction]. In this review, “p.” refers to the page number printed in the original book, not the page of the reproduction. The distinction matters because the latter commonly contains two book pages. (Publication details, p. 4; contents, p. 5.)

In his preface, the author speaks of dedicating the volume to the memory of his father, Ramlakhan Jha, the difficulties of literary publication, and the motivation to pursue research continuously. The dedication thus becomes not merely an external formality but autobiographical evidence. The writer of the foreword establishes a relationship between research and criticism, identifying Jha's studies of folklore, literary criticism, and linguistics as achievements of the collection. Read together, the two preliminary pieces make the volume appear to announce a programme of work in addition to its wide range of subjects: to accord equal research importance to folk memory, written literature, and the history of words. (Foreword, printed pp. i–iv; preface.)

In this critical study, the original text is treated as the principal evidence. Wherever printing or another textual difficulty made the exact wording uncertain, no conjectural expressions, unverified figures, or fabricated quotations have been supplied. External checks are restricted to selected bibliographies, the Sahitya Akademi's records, and the research context of the Deshinamamala. The author's original assertions and observations from contemporary scholarship have not been substituted for one another.

Research Questions and Critical Criteria

The principal question in evaluating this collection is: what does Yoganand Jha regard as evidence, how does he classify it, how does he construct literary meaning from it, and how cautious is he in drawing conclusions? In the essay on folklore, oral tradition, proverbs, songs, and tales are the primary materials. In the essays on Vidyapati and Suman, texts and concepts of poetics form the basis. In the essay on journalism, the history and documentation of periodicals predominate. In the essays on regional vocabulary, comparative study of historical etymology, variation, and semantic development is the central method. The author's treatment of these differing kinds of evidence must be examined by criteria appropriate to each, rather than by a single undifferentiated standard.

The review proceeds on two levels. First, it reconstructs as accurately as possible the positions advanced within the book. Second, it asks how strong the connection is between example and argument, where classification is useful or insufficient, where the social perspective opens out or narrows, and to what extent a researcher today can use the chapter as evidence or argument. Without distinguishing these levels, a research review may become merely a favourable introduction or may commit the error of retroactively imposing present-day assumptions upon an earlier writer.

1. “Maithili Folk Literature”: The Forms and Classification of Oral Tradition (pp. 13–30)

The Basic Concepts of “Folk” and “Folk Literature”

The author opens this extended essay by explaining the social meaning of the word “folk”. For him, folk literature is primarily the domain of ordinary people's experience, memory, beliefs, practices, and collective expression. Its distinction from written or classical literature is not merely a matter of script: it includes collective authorship, oral transmission, occasions of performance, and a living relationship with custom. Discussing the categories of rasa, dhvani, alamkara, and riti, he suggests that the creation of folk literature cannot be measured by the regular disciplines of Sanskrit poetics. This constitutes an important insistence on the autonomous artistry of folk literature. (pp. 13–14.)

Yet this opening also has a limitation. In distinguishing folk expression from classical convention, the author sometimes treats oral literature as spontaneous and uncontrived. Folk songs have their own rigorous structures of

metre, tune, repetition, sequence, and ceremonial rule. It is therefore more appropriate to understand the difference between the folk and the classical not as a conflict between rules and their absence but as two kinds of traditional discipline. This objection arises from the book's own examples: it records fixed sequences of lines and prescribed occasions of performance in several songs.

The Original Contribution of the Classification

On pages 14–15 the author discusses earlier classifications and offers an integrated scheme. The most useful element of the essay is the diagrammatic classification seeking to place Maithili folk literature in relation to visual and aural genres. Folk dance and folk theatre belong to the visual side; the aural side distinguishes sung from spoken material. Sung forms include folk epics, narrative ballads, and folk songs; spoken forms include folktales, proverbs, idioms, oral traditions and legends, pithy sayings, maxims, folk incantations, and riddles. This ordering resists the tendency to make the folk song synonymous with all folk literature. (Especially the printed classification chart, pp. 14–15.)

A critical examination of this scheme must note that folk theatre often combines song, speech, and spectacle. A folk epic is both a narrative and a performance; the boundary between the narrative ballad and the folk song is not fixed; and the delivery of a riddle can itself be a performance. The author's map is consequently useful for collecting materials and designing curricula, but treating it as a definitive scientific boundary would conceal the intermingling of genres. A more precise catalogue would have separate fields for “form”, “medium of performance”, “function”, “occasion”, and “performing community”.

From Folk Song to Folk Epic: The Social Context of the Text

The essay discusses life-cycle songs, marriage customs, village life, ritual, seasonal occasions, and the distinctive singing traditions of caste and community. The author seeks to understand folk songs in relation to devotional, ceremonial, and occasional contexts. In this account, a song emerges not simply as a verbal text but as an expression bound to the actions of life. “When was it sung?” and “By whom?” become integral questions of meaning. The presentation of lines alongside their social contexts enables the reader to apprehend both levels. (pp. 16–21.)

In discussing folk epics, the author attends to the relation between narrative expansion and sung form. Narrative enters song; local heroes, communities, love, valour, and folk beliefs enter narrative. These examples give a partial glimpse of the oral history of Maithili tradition, but they should not be mistaken for factual historical records of the events described. Folk epics are composite constructions of historical memory, imagination, and social value. The author's material can support distinct inquiries into all three. (pp. 18–20.)

The Range of Tales, Proverbs, Maxims, Incantations, and Riddles

In considering folktales, the author provides examples of plots and modes of narration; in oral traditions and legends, the social acceptance of a narrative belief becomes important. Proverbs, idioms, and pithy sayings are discussed as compact verbal expressions of folk knowledge. A proverb's few words can hold an expansive meaning, satire, practical warning, and experience of human relations. This makes the collection useful not only for literary study but also from a sociolinguistic perspective. (pp. 22–26.)

The discussion of folk incantations and riddles further enlarges the book's scope. In an incantation, belief, fear of illness, or the desire for protection from danger finds expression through language; in a riddle, imagination becomes an intellectual game. In assessing these forms it is important to distinguish the cultural role of an incantation from proof of therapeutic efficacy, and to recognize the verbal construction on which the answer to a riddle depends. The book's linguistic examples merit study, but medical, religious, or historical claims still require independent verification. (pp. 26–28.)

The History of Collection and Critical Limitations

In the essay's final part, the author reflects on earlier efforts to collect Maithili folklore, the difficulties of research, and the necessity of preserving materials. His principal concern is to secure endangered oral traditions in written form. The book of 2002 thus confronts a continuing question: transcribing the words of a folk song does not, by itself, preserve its tune, singing style, occasion, audience response, or multiple versions. Consequently, the classification on pages 13–30 may be regarded as a preliminary framework for field documentation, not as a complete archive.

The essay's overall achievement is to establish connections among songs, tales, proverbs, folk incantations, and drama in the study of Maithili folklore. But the material would have been more verifiable for contemporary folklorists had each collected instance been accompanied by separate evidence of location, informant, date of collection, and variant readings. This criticism does not diminish the examples' importance; rather, it regards them as a useful starting point for future archival work.

2. “The Mallah Community in Proverbs”: The Relationship between Occupation and Proverb (pp. 31–35)

The Occupational Vocabulary of Social Life

Through sayings and proverbs associated with the Mallah community, the author introduces Mithila's river-centred life. He connects the vocabulary of fish, makhana, water chestnuts, boats, nets, fishing rods, baskets, fish species, and aquatic creatures with statements about social conduct. His main proposition is that an occupation is not merely an economic activity: it shapes the language in which a community expresses experience. Expressions derived

from the tools and actions of water-related work eventually become similes, satire, or warnings in other social situations. (pp. 31–32.)

The author mentions community surnames and subdivisions, establishing a broader social background for occupational identity. But this information should not be taken as an exhaustive contemporary classification of communities: it is the description given in this book, not recent demographic data verified by survey. Read with this distinction, the essay becomes a vocabulary-rich source for social history. (p. 31.)

From the Literal Meaning of Implements to Metaphor

The author finds references to "spreading a net", steering a boat, rowing, fishing rods, and fish in many proverbs. The actual extension of a net becomes an image of spreading one's reach; a fish caught by a hook may suggest greater caution born of experience; a boatman's skill may become a metaphor for social leadership or the management of affairs. These examples reveal the movement from a direct occupational action to an indirect social meaning. The essay thereby provides material for a study of folk metaphor beyond the investigation of word meanings. (pp. 31–33.)

Alongside sayings about the different names, flavours, values, and habits of fish, the author describes food culture and market exchange. Episodes such as the conjunction of trade in dried fish (sukathi) and pilgrimage to Pashupatinath bring together several social meanings in one saying, extending from livelihood to religious travel. Such instances are useful for study, but the essay supplies no independent documentary evidence that the trading practices described in the proverbs always existed in precisely that form. The social imagination of a proverb must therefore be distinguished from documentary history. (p. 33.)

An Analysis of Humour, Satire, and Prejudice

The sayings contain pointed observations on intelligence, idleness, greed, miserliness, hospitality, advantage, and misfortune. The supposed asceticism of the heron and the habits of fish, turtles, or crabs become occasions for folk moral instruction. The author explains the sense of these expressions individually, enabling the general reader to grasp their contexts. This interpretive effort is a distinct achievement of the essay. (pp. 33–35.)

Nevertheless, it is doubtful that humour and the use of proverbs can be treated as neutral evidence of folk wisdom. Mockery directed at occupations and castes, hierarchies of food, or traits attributed to communities may also register social relations of power. Where those who utter a proverb differ from its target community, satire may be accompanied by the language of domination. Future research should therefore ask how Mallah communities themselves understand the proverbs concerning them. The collection prompts this question, although the author does not make it his principal subject.

Conclusion of the Essay

The real value of this five-page essay is not merely the number of proverbs but its illumination of the relationship between occupational vocabulary and social meaning. At the outset, the author describes water-related occupations as an important foundation of Mithila's ancient life and, at the end, treats the spread of the proverbs as evidence for that background. Yet the prevalence of sayings does not, by itself, establish the historical conclusion that this was the "most ancient occupation". Archaeological, economic, and archival sources would be necessary. It is more consonant with the evidence to receive his conclusion here as a historical hypothesis arising from folk literature.

3. "The Character of Radha in Vidyapati": Multiple Readings of Devotion, Desire, and Poetry (pp. 36–42)

Many Readings of the Same Radha

At the outset Radha is presented as a figure in Indian literature and religious imagination in whom love, attachment, bodily beauty, surrender, and spirituality acquire differing meanings. Rather than confining her to a fixed religious symbol, Yoganand Jha examines Vidyapati's lyric corpus through three interpretive domains: Vaishnava thought, the classical discourse of desire, and literary poetics. The essay thus becomes not a mere repetition of established opinions but a discussion of the methods of textual interpretation. (pp. 36–37.)

An Examination of Radha's Vaishnava Form

Describing Radha's Vaishnava form, the author discusses the Puranic tradition, love for Krishna, the views of the Nadia and Sahajiya Vaishnava traditions, and the metaphor of individual and supreme souls. The distinction is clear: a lyric of affective love may be read as religious experience or as worldly separation; both possibilities remain open to the reader. By setting out divergences among critics, the author demonstrates that the interpretation of Radha's feelings established in Bengali Vaishnava contexts cannot be applied uniformly to every lyric by Vidyapati. (pp. 37–39.)

A particular strength of this argument is its resistance to reading that admits only one meaning. When Radha's separation is treated solely as a spiritual symbol, the body, social risk, public shame, and suffering of love may be neglected; when it is treated solely as worldly eroticism, the history of the lyrics' reception and reinterpretation in devotional traditions may disappear. The discussion allows both extremes to be scrutinized. The argument would have been stronger in its chronology had Vidyapati's original historical setting and the later Vaishnava reception of his poems been separated into distinct sections.

The Erotological Form and Questions of Moral Judgement

The essay's second aspect is the treatment of Radha through classical erotology (kama-shastra). Here the author relates representations of female beauty, the gestures of love, states of erotic union, descriptions of the body,

scenes of pleasure, and embodied experience to textual evidence. This provides a means of viewing Radha not solely as a transcendent object of worship but as an experiencing heroine created by the poet. Discussing charges of obscenity levelled against Vidyapati, the author regards the artistic sensitivity with which the suffering of the separated Radha is rendered as a significant answer to those accusations. (pp. 39–40.)

Its critical achievement lies in separating the artistic question of sexual expression from moral denunciation. But there is also a danger in placing every image of beauty under an erotological classification: reducing a poem's feeling, the speaker's position, exchanges with companions, humour, modesty, and symbolism to an inventory of kama-shastra diminishes its original dramatic quality. The article contains extensive evidence, but gives comparatively little direct attention to textual variants and the musical contexts of the songs. Both would enrich the multilayered interpretation of Radha.

The Uses of Classification in Poetics

In the third major part Radha is examined as the supporting object of the erotic sentiment (shringara-rasa), in relation to classifications of heroines and to expressive and transitory emotions. The author discusses such categories and conditions as svakīyā and parakīyā, mugdhā, madhyā and prauḍhā, the heroine on her way to a tryst (abhisārikā), the aggrieved heroine (khaṇḍitā), the proud or offended heroine (māninī), and the woman suffering in separation (virahiṇī). The usefulness of this list is that Radha ceases to be a motionless icon and appears as a character transformed by particular circumstances. The same heroine expresses differing social and emotional responses on different occasions of love. (pp. 40–41.)

The limits of such classification lie in the relation between poetry and poetics. The critic's task is not merely to prove that a lyric falls within a named type of heroine; the central question is how Vidyapati's poetic language transforms the traditional category within that lyric. The book's final insistence on seeing Radha's many forms together suggests an answer to this limitation. Criticizing one-sided scholarly interpretations, the author regards Radha as a confluence of aesthetic experience, spiritual practice, beauty, and feeling. (pp. 41–42.)

Overall Assessment

The essay's central contribution is not to proclaim a single “final Radha” but to clarify the limitations of the different interpretive instruments used to examine her. Sectarian reception, literary theory, and worldly experience thus enter into dialogue within Vidyapati scholarship. For the critic, this multiplicity is itself an enrichment of literature. For the researcher, the lesson is to distinguish the lyric's context, language, feeling, textual variants, and later interpretations as separate categories of evidence before advancing an integrated conclusion.

4. “The Character of Parvati in Vidyapati”: Shakta Thought and the Realities of Domestic Life (pp. 43–52)

From a Mythological Figure to the Experiences of Mithila's Women

The author begins his study of Parvati by referring to three social conditions of womanhood: daughter, wife, and mother. Presenting the Puranic identities of Gauri, Uma, Bhavani, and Maheshwari, he moves from the marriage-related observances of Gauri worship in Mithila to Vidyapati's lyrics. The method shows how the story of Shiva and Parvati acquires local cultural meanings and becomes a narrative of family life. The worship of Gauri is not only veneration of a deity but also a social expression of beliefs concerning a desired husband, marital good fortune, companionship, and domestic stability. (pp. 43–44.)

This beginning establishes a close connection between culture and literature. Despite the distance between Parvati's mythological eminence and an ordinary daughter's constraints in marriage, the author sees their mutual entry into Vidyapati's lyrics. The essay should therefore not be considered a mere characterization of Shiva and Parvati. Questions of the institution of marriage, women's autonomy in decision-making, economic hardship, and family honour and humiliation recur throughout its reading.

The Duality of Supreme Power and Domestic Character

With reference to the Devi-Mahatmya, the essay examines Gauri as the supreme divine power, para-shakti. By describing the consolidation of the powers of Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva, the ideas of creation, preservation, and destruction, and the goddess's various forms, the author establishes the background of Shakta literature. This is necessary because in Vidyapati's lyrics, the domestic conduct of Shiva's wife appears alongside the grandeur of the goddess as the embodiment of power. Without both the worldly and transcendent levels, the portrayal of Gauri would remain incomplete. (pp. 44–45.)

The analysis of this duality is among the author's finest critical undertakings. On one side Parvati is the power of the universe; on the other she is a distressed woman faced with a small income, begging, irregular access to food, and her husband's intoxicant use. Rather than treating these portraits as contradictory, one may see their tension as a source of poetic meaning. When the goddess speaks in the voice of an ordinary housewife's anxieties, the audience brings a religious figure into familiar surroundings. Vidyapati's humour and compassion reinforce each other in this transformation. (pp. 47–51.)

Early Attraction, Marriage, and Ill-Matched Unions

Discussing Parvati's first stirrings of love, the author describes Gauri's attraction upon seeing the ascetic Shiva, Mena's misgivings, the suitor's appearance, age, and poverty, and social pressures surrounding marriage. The anger of Mena before people who ridicule Shiva's ugliness and penury conceals

a mother's fears. The author connects the episode with experiences of ill-matched marriages in Maithil society. In this connection the mythological narrative acquires the force of social criticism. (pp. 45–46.)

The important question is how a daughter's wishes and the family's decision are related in marriage. On the basis of several lyrics, the author finds Gauri's fidelity in love and her family's helplessness within the same story. Yet when the old ideal of treating acquiescence under compulsion as exemplary feminine duty takes precedence, a woman's independent desire can recede. The material itself reveals this tension: Gauri loves, witnesses a setting of opposition or discontent, and subsequently makes a place for herself within social propriety. A critical reading should register both dedication and resistance.

Marital Fidelity, Neglect by the Natal Family, and Economic Insecurity

The author quotes numerous verses concerning the married Gauri's fidelity to her husband. Shiva's humiliation, its effects upon relationships between the marital and natal households, and the scorn endured by a financially incapable husband bring the social and class realities of Mithila's conjugal life into view. Particularly revealing is the episode of Shiva's disrespectful reception in Gauri's natal home and her silent humiliation and pain. The author interprets this silence as a conflict of shame, affection, pride, and propriety. (pp. 46–48.)

In passages about financial deprivation, Shiva's begging and the poverty of the household become central causes. Gauri's anxiety is not merely greed for wealth but a practical concern for food, shelter, clothing, and family subsistence. At this point the essay becomes a socio-economic reading rather than simply literary criticism. The author recognizes the economic pressures borne by women's work and domestic life in the Shaiva lyrics. This reading permits Vidyapati's songs of Shiva to be seen beyond devotional texts, as poetic forms of social documentation. (pp. 48–49.)

Counsel, Opposition to Intoxicants, and the Active Wife

The interpretation of Parvati's role as counsellor (sāchivya) is an important original dimension of the essay. Gauri urges Shiva to work and cultivate the land, reflects upon the injury to his standing caused by begging, and worries about the consequences of consuming bhang. This woman is not simply her husband's follower: she exercises considered judgement in household economics and conduct. The author sees her counsel as expressing the compassion, affection, and reforming initiative associated with a wife. (pp. 50–51.)

A distinction is necessary here for modern criticism. Within the ideal of marital fidelity, the wife becomes the agent of her husband's reform; but her questions about addiction, the distribution of labour, and the allocation of resources also testify to women's critical awareness. Parvati's speech concerns not only sacrifice but decision-making within the family. Read in this way, the author's examples further reveal the social seriousness of the songs.

Principal Critical Achievement

In this essay, Vidyapati's Parvati appears as an icon of Shakta worship, a young woman consumed by love, a woman caught in the tensions of marriage, a wife bearing humiliation, and a practical adviser in domestic life. The validity of the author's analysis rests on this many-sided characterization. Yet a comparison of Mithila's popular marriage songs with the textual traditions of Vidyapati's original lyrics would clarify which motifs are the poet's particular creations and which belong to wider Maithili folk tradition. The evidence assembled in the book offers ample grounds for such inquiry.

5. "Women in Suman's Muktaka Poetry": Tradition, Nature, and the Social Images of Women (pp. 53–64)

Four Principal Categories of Criticism

The essay on Suman's poetry examines women's portrayal in four main categories: the mythological, the figure projected upon nature, the categories of poetics, and the worldly. These are not simply convenient headings: each entails a change in the woman's position, her manner of representation, and the poet's emotional intention. The author first considers the dignity accorded to women within Indian cultural thought, then elaborates these four images on the basis of numerous poems by Suman. (pp. 53–54.)

The principal advantage of this classification is that it does not confine women to erotic roles. The goddess's power, the living personification of nature, the poetic heroine, and the individual in family and society each serve distinct cultural purposes. Yet the relations among these categories cannot go unquestioned. Motherhood belongs to both the mythological and the worldly; a woman projected onto nature may also be constructed from conventional images of erotic poetics. The classification therefore assists study without claiming that the realities it distinguishes are entirely separate.

The Mythological Goddess and Domestic Labour

Under the mythological category, the author considers woman as a form of Shakti, the goddess's many names, the conception of creative and sustaining power, and Suman's hymns to the divine feminine. Significantly, after this elevated classical portrayal the essay turns to a vivid depiction of a woman's everyday domestic labour. The woman occupied with the household, courtyard, children, cleaning, and family arrangements is shown as a social embodiment of Shakti. The poems' domestic activities thus become images of women's competence and their socially invisible work. (pp. 54–55.)

There is a tension here. Calling the woman of the house a goddess is a language of respect, but that respect should not obscure the unequal distribution of her labour, restricted educational opportunities, or limits upon her autonomy. The essay praises Suman's sensitive portrayal but gives comparatively little critical scrutiny to the social obligations imposed upon women under the rubric of domestic power. Readers today will see both idealization and reality in these poems.

The Feminization of Nature: The Work of Imagery

The section on women projected upon nature depicts the moon, moonlight, creepers, new leaves, seasons, rivers, and weather as human beings. Relating women's appearance, age, voice, feelings, and tenderness to natural scenes and experiences, the author elucidates the aesthetic arrangement of Suman's poetry. To imagine moonlight (ijoriya) as a woman is a distinctive poetic device: the external world acquires significance through human relationships. (pp. 55–57.)

An important observation is that representations of natural beauty are also associated with women's inward suffering, compassion, and motherhood. Whether the image is of autumn as an elderly mother or the rainy season as a tender, nurturing nature, the attempt is to carry women's lives beyond a narrow celebration of youthful beauty. On the strength of such examples, criticism of nature poetry becomes a history of feeling rather than a mere catalogue of figures of speech. (pp. 57–58.)

Yet the cultural politics of feminizing nature must also be questioned. Treating women as "naturally" nurturing, self-sacrificing, and beautiful can present socially assigned roles as facts of nature. While accepting the artistry of Suman's imagery, one must also examine which social expectations are reinforced by these metaphors and which experiences of living disappear from view. The author's critical materials are useful for reconsideration at this level.

Types of Heroines, "Lalana-Lahari", and Conventional Craft

In the section on poetics, the author reads poems through descriptions of beauty from head to toe, categories of heroines, the threshold of adolescence, ornamentation, regional distinctions, rasa, and literary modes. In works such as "Lalana-Lahari", he identifies poetic classifications of women's beauty and dispositions according to region and the application of distinctions inherited from Sanskrit poetics. He also acknowledges that some portraits merely repeat older conventions and show limited novelty. Such self-awareness is a merit of the essay: its assessments are not wholly laudatory. (pp. 58–61.)

The abundance of poetic terminology lends this section scholarly weight, but there is less examination of the opportunities women have to speak for themselves. A catalogue of heroine-types frequently represents its figures from an external point of view. A contemporary researcher would ask how much individual female speech, dialogue, decision, and resistance Suman's works contain. Classification of appearances alone cannot answer that question.

Worldly Women: Beloved, Wife, Daughter, and Mother

Under the worldly category, the author considers several stages of family relations. A daughter's departure upon marriage, a beloved's hopes, companionship in married life, maternal affection, and a widow's suffering extend the emotional range of female experience. In poems of national feeling and the inspiration to action, women are invoked as embodiments of strength. The author treats these varied images as testimony to the poet's social awareness and compassion. (pp. 61–64.)

The discussion's strength lies in its gradual movement from the appreciation of beauty to social feeling. Yet an inventory of "mother, wife, sister, daughter" does not exhaust the definition of woman as an autonomous citizen. The relative absence of individual consciousness in the writer, labourer, learner, or woman making her own decisions may itself become a subject for study. Taking account of the author's historical situation, it is fairer to understand Suman's portrayal of women through the duality of the poet's sensitivity and conventional gender roles.

Overall Evaluation

The importance of this twelve-page essay is that the author brings together mythology, nature, poetics, and family in his discussion of the literary imagination of womanhood. It provides a basis for critically distinguishing conventional poetic splendour from the realities of women's domestic lives. Future research based on this essay would benefit from separate consideration of the dates of Suman's original publications, differences among collections, and women's independent voices.

6. "Amarji and His History of Maithili Journalism": A Review of a Writer's Creativity and Historiography (pp. 65–78)

From a Biographical Essay to a Book Review

In this essay, Dr Yoganand Jha first describes Chandranath Mishra "Amar" as a teacher and literary figure, and his involvement in poetry, humour and satire, drama, fiction, and journalism. He then examines the purpose, evidence, periodization, treatment of periodicals, and conclusions of Amarji's History of Maithili Journalism. The piece is neither an ordinary biographical sketch nor a celebratory review; it attempts to establish connections between a historian's lived experiences and the methods of the history he wrote. (pp. 65–73.)

The essay introduces Amarji's poetry collections, his work in humour and satire, association with literary journals, and opposition to social conventions. The author argues that a writer persistently attentive to social contradictions may also discern living social processes in a history of journalism. This is a plausible connection, but literary talent does not automatically establish the evidential reliability of historical writing. Historical claims must be tested against original journals, issues, editorials, chronologies, and documents. The latter portion of the essay, fortunately, turns to precisely such questions of sources.

The Significance of Active Participation in Journalism

The author attaches importance to Amarji's active role in editing journals, writing columns, and extending Maithili's public circulation. Practical experience of the difficulties of periodicals—gathering material, editing, publishing, readership, and distribution—can help a historian understand their institutional dimension. The essay mentions his activities associated with Vaidehi, Swadesh, and other periodicals in this context. (pp. 71–73.)

But the central critical question is how deeply a historian's personal attachment enters an assessment of a movement in which he himself participated. Proximity provides rare material but can also introduce partiality. Yoganand Jha regards Amarji's experience as an important qualification; the researcher should recognize its value while testing assertions with independent evidence. First-hand experience and archival impartiality complement one another; they are not automatically identical.

The Structure of History of Maithili Journalism

According to the author's account, the history discusses theories of journalism, the social role of journals and newspapers, the responsibilities of publishers and editors, and the development of Maithili journalism. On page 74, the period covered is given as 1905–1979 and the number of periodicals as eighty-seven. This figure is a detail from Amarji's historical work as quoted by Yoganand Jha, not an exhaustive count for all periods of Maithili journalism. The essay examines the periodization of journals according to their publication dates, types, and linguistic-cultural contributions. (pp. 73–75.)

The strength of this approach is that it treats periodicals not simply as a list of titles but as vehicles of institutional history. Which publication contributed to education, which became a voice of language activism, which raised social questions, and which could not survive for financial or editorial reasons? Such questions enlarge the history of journalism into social history. The author commends Amarji's integrated assessment of political, educational, linguistic, and cultural contributions.

Chronology, Corrections, and the Testing of Authenticity

The essay addresses differences between historians over the founding year, editorship, and republication of journals. Yoganand Jha particularly values Amarji's efforts to correct several earlier misconceptions. He emphasizes the chronology of the book and discusses its indication of approximately three stages in the history of journalism. (pp. 76–77.)

Such comparisons are important to the evidential reliability of historical writing. Nevertheless, a decisive assertion that an earlier view was mistaken can be accepted on the basis of internal argument only after the relevant original issue or document has been seen. This review treats the corrections as historical claims made in the source book, not as independently verified facts. That caution preserves the essay's usefulness and makes the researcher's responsibility explicit.

The Book's Incompleteness and the Dispute over Its Title

Yoganand Jha also recognizes the incompleteness of Amarji's history: all issues of every journal were not available, and some discussions consequently depended upon available materials or earlier opinions. Responding to objections to the title “History of Journalism”, he argues against confining journalism to the running of daily newspapers. Journals, public exchange of ideas, civic awareness, editorial interventions, and social movements also

belong to the wider meaning of journalism. This is the author's position. (pp. 77–78.)

The argument over naming is persuasive. To define journalism solely through daily publication would neglect the public interventions of weekly, fortnightly, and monthly periodicals. Even so, methodological distinctions should be maintained between the history of journalism, an inventory of periodicals, and editorial-cultural history. The author defends the title; future research can separately specify the source materials and analytical questions appropriate to each undertaking.

Facts Confirmed by External Records

The Sahitya Akademi's official award list identifies Chandranath Mishra "Amar" as the recipient of the 1983 Maithili Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili Patrakaritaka Itihas. A Japanese CiNii library record for the book identifies Chandranath Mishra "Amar" as its author, the Maithili Akademi of Patna as publisher, 1981 as its year of publication, and 405 pages as the length of the main text. These two facts are supported by external references. The other periodical dates and editorial details mentioned in Yoganand Jha's essay have not all been independently checked in this chapter. (External sources: Sahitya Akademi award list; CiNii, BA83217091.)

Overall Assessment

The essay's greatest significance lies in how a literary biography illuminates connections among the historical evidence of Maithili journalism, editorial traditions, and language activism. Its recognition of the historical book's incompleteness also prevents the review from becoming mere praise. Nevertheless, the corrections made in that book need renewed examination against original records, together with comprehensive digital catalogues of individual periodicals and details of institutional finances. Raising these questions extends the author's own research impulse.

7. "Description, Dialogue, and Language in Maithili Fiction": A Historical Study of Narrative Craft (pp. 79–93)

The Elements of Fiction and the Question of Form

Listing six principal elements of fiction, the author regards description, dialogue, and language as means of communicating plot and character effectively. The task of fiction is not simply to recount events but to convey a character's inner life, pressures of environment, the movement of events, and the reader's experience. In this view, the writer connects form with subject matter and characterization. To understand craft not as external decoration but as an active means of producing narrative meaning is the essay's essential method. (pp. 79–80.)

In the introduction the author discusses several qualities of modern fiction: organization, suspense, concision, psychological depth, appropriate dialogue, and expressive language. These are useful critical criteria, but not every experiment in modern fiction follows the same structural pattern or climax.

Fragmentation, unreliable narration, and deliberately subdued endings may also be resources of contemporary fiction. The proposed qualities should therefore be treated as descriptive criteria rather than compulsory rules of poetics.

The Historical Development of the Maithili Short Story

The author distinguishes early translations, narrative prose and tale-like writing, didactic prose, and modern original fiction. After discussing print culture, language contact, and the influence of Bengali fiction, he traces the evolution of Maithili storytelling towards critiques of social evils, condensed plots, and the psychological portrayal of character. References to Harimohan Jha and numerous later storytellers alongside early authors connect the discussion to literary history rather than allowing it to remain abstract theory. (pp. 80–81.)

A caution is needed in constructing this history. A linear progression from "translation" to "originality" and from "instruction" to "psychology" may obscure the diversity of narrative styles coexisting within the same period. Translated stories can involve creative transformation; folk narratives and modern short fiction are not wholly disconnected. The developmental sequence supplies a useful introduction, but its alternative branches call for a separate source-based history.

Descriptive Detail and Concision in Narrative Language

In the discussion of description, the author compares the ornamented, lengthy, poetical representation of early prose with the demands of modern fiction. Descriptive power is necessary to make characters, scenes, and events vivid, but excessive ornament can impede narrative movement. The author regards the tendency to contain "an ocean in a pitcher"—much meaning within few words—as a formal achievement of the modern story, and on that basis distinguishes indispensable detail from unnecessary expansion. (pp. 82–84.)

The practical benefit of this argument is clear. A writer may ask of each sentence of scenic description: what new meaning does it bring to event, character, or feeling? Yet ornate prose is not in itself a flaw. Extended description may be necessary to portray social irony, the narrator's personality, linguistic memory, or the density of a local setting. "Fewer words" should not become a universal measure of "better fiction". The examples cited by the author are best understood through analysis of what style actually does.

Character Portrayal, the Social Scene, and Inner Experience

The author also examines the depiction of a character's clothing, physical appearance, emotions, social circumstances, and historical situation. Such descriptions bring fiction from abstract moral statement into a concrete social world. Examples associated with class conflict, the rural economy, exploitation, and displacement show that social reality may become apparent in the story's opening scene. Description need not slow plot; it can create expectations for what will happen next. (pp. 83–85.)

The discussion of psychological fiction is equally important. Moving from accounts of external acts to the representation of a character's anxieties, inferiority, anger, love, or confusion intensifies the reader's experience. But "inside" and "outside" are not inherently separate: bodily gesture, forms of social address, domestic objects, and silence can also disclose psychological states. Rereading the examples in this light would reduce the artificial opposition between social and psychological fiction.

The Drama of Dialogue and the Making of Character

The essay regards dialogue as a vital means of advancing the action and revealing character. The author examines dramatic exchanges, dialogue without identifying tags, and natural speech in everyday life. His examples show how dialogue can reduce the narrator's external commentary, establish a character's class-inflected language, or advance the story through conversation alone. (pp. 85–87.)

When the author considers the quantity and function of dialogue and points towards conversation-dominated storytelling, he raises important questions about genre boundaries. Fiction may retain its narrative structure even when dialogue predominates, as in drama. The question is not how many lines of speech occur but how readers perceive unspoken tensions between characters, gaps in the plot, and implications of utterance. The naturalness of dialogue is thus not a mere copy of speech but a result of artistic selection.

Sanskritized, Literary, and Colloquial Language

In the section on language, the author examines changing forms of Maithili narrative prose. After the early predominance of Sanskritized diction, the uses of fluent literary Maithili, ordinary conversation, class-specific speech, and regional pronunciations are presented as extensions of literary sensibility. He attaches particular importance to the linguistic construction of Harimohan Jha's writing. Here we find an indication of the democratization of narrative language: forms once dismissed as "rustic" can enter the centre of literary expression because characters and subject matter require them. (pp. 87–90.)

The author praises language appropriate to the caste, occupation, and regional experience of individual characters. At this point the essay enters into dialogue with the collection's opening study of folklore. The oral expression of the folk, first examined as an autonomous object of literary study, becomes an instrument of modern composition in the seventh essay. Read together, they reveal the breadth of Yoganand Jha's linguistic perspective.

Objections to Artificial Dialect and the Use of Other Languages

One pointed aspect of the essay is its criticism of storytellers who try to invent the speech of rural or lower-class characters without adequate acquaintance with their lives. The author calls such usage artificial language. The objection has force: absence of social experience may produce not merely a linguistic fault but a failure of representation. Presenting dialect as strange or ridiculous can diminish a character's dignity. (pp. 90–91.)

In discussing Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Bhojpuri, English, and other languages, the author distinguishes natural mixing appropriate to a character from irrelevant intrusion. The distinction is sound, but the label "foreign" or "other" language needs examination against the realities of contemporary multilingual life. Cities, migration, education, markets, digital communication, and cross-border relationships make mixed language an authentic aspect of characterization. A word's origin in another language is not, on its own, proof of a defect; contextual truth and artistic function are more appropriate tests. (pp. 91–92.)

Critical Judgement

This fifteen-page essay outlines the grammar of fiction while presenting a history of language in Maithili prose. Although description, dialogue, and language are discussed separately, all three depend on one another in the creation of narrative meaning. A comparison with other chapters shows the author's strong support for the capacities of everyday speech, alongside an occasionally stringent commitment to standardization in matters of ease and linguistic correctness. This tension is particularly valuable to the study of debates about Maithili language.

8. "The Concept of Deshi Words": Limits of Etymology and the Classification of Vocabulary (pp. 94–98)

The Problem of "Deshi" Goes Beyond the Merely "Local" Word

The essay begins by distinguishing tatsama, tadbhava, borrowed, and deshi words. In ordinary usage a word whose Sanskrit or other known source is not apparent is called "deshi", "deshaj", or "theth" (indigenous or locally rooted). The author provides examples from Maithili and cautions that an "unknown etymology" is not itself conclusive evidence of an origin unrelated to Sanskrit. As linguistic knowledge changes, the classification of a word may also change. This is the essay's most important proposition. (p. 94.)

Etymological inquiry proceeds on several levels. A word's sounds, meaning, historical use, forms in neighbouring languages, rules of sound change, and possible borrowing must all be considered before conclusions about its origin are drawn. Here the author principally assesses earlier theorists. The essential lesson is that not finding a word's source is not the same thing as establishing that no such source ever existed.

Differences among the Early Authorities

Referring to Bharata, Dandin, Rudrata, and Hemachandra, the author traces the historical development of classifications of words. Across this history the sense of "deshi" changes with writer and period: sometimes it describes popular expressions distinct from Sanskrit-derived forms, sometimes words of unknown etymology, and sometimes words used in Prakrit literature. What matters is not a fixed definition but the questions and responses within scholarly tradition. (pp. 94–95.)

In discussing Hemachandra's definition, the work emphasizes the relations among unknown origins, forms not derivable by grammatical rules, altered senses recorded in Sanskrit lexicons, and long-standing use in Prakrit literature. Placing deshi words in a rigid camp opposed to Sanskrit oversimplifies this history. The presentation makes clear that medieval lexicographers' classifications were devised for particular grammatical and lexical purposes. (p. 95.)

Reconsiderations by Modern Linguists

The essay discusses differences among Pischel, Grierson, Suniti Kumar Chatterji, and other scholars. Some perspectives find in deshi vocabulary unexpected or indirectly developed forms of ancient Indo-Aryan; some consider possible contact with Dravidian, Munda, and other languages; still others relate unknown origins to the limits of linguists' knowledge. The author's conclusion is not that every opinion is equally true, but that the category "deshi" is less certain than it may seem when scanning a conventional dictionary list. (pp. 96–97.)

The author's caution raises questions consistent with modern historical linguistics. Resemblance of sounds or meanings does not by itself establish etymology; regular sound correspondences, historical chronology, and the direction of language contact must be examined. Both extremes are inappropriate: declaring a word non-Indo-Aryan simply because it is not found in Sanskrit, and proposing Sanskrit origins for every word. The methodological importance of the essay's argument extends beyond this particular subject.

The Difference between "Unknown" and "Under Investigation"

The concluding argument regards the concept of the deshi word as provisional and dependent upon the limits of linguistic knowledge. A word may be called deshi until its original source becomes clear; further evidence may alter the classification. This is useful to linguistic research because a lexicographical label becomes an indication of the present state of inquiry rather than an unalterable identity. (p. 97.)

In practice, however, deshi has another meaning: local speech, distinctive style, intimacy, and the identity of a community. A word may remain "theth" for its speakers even after its historical derivation has been established. It would therefore be useful to describe etymological deshi and sociolinguistic deshi separately. The essay principally addresses the first; the second emerges when it is read alongside the book's studies of folklore.

9. "Deshinamamala and Maithili": A Comparative Study of Changes in Sound and Meaning (pp. 99–104)

The Relationship between a Historical Lexicon and Maithili

In the final essay, the author compares the forms and meanings of Maithili vocabulary with words recorded in Hemachandra's Deshinamamala. The central argument is that some words preserved in this Prakrit lexicon have

identical or closely related forms in Maithili; examining this continuity together with phonetic and semantic changes yields evidence for the language's historical development. The method does not rest solely on saying that "the words look alike"; it uses categories such as additions of sounds, formal modification, assimilation, semantic narrowing, and semantic extension. (pp. 99–104.)

This essay naturally extends the preceding discussion of the concept of deshi words. The eighth asks about the principles of classification; the ninth applies comparison to actual lexical items. The sequence is one strength of the collection's composition. Theory is tested against words, and examples are placed within linguistic categories.

Historical Strata in Living Vocabulary

On pages 99–101 the author presents several pairs of words, comparing historical lexicon entries with Maithili forms such as orhna, kosia, kasauni, khali, jhankhar, bulbulla, and os. They concern objects, clothing, food, weather, and daily activities. The significance of their selection is that historical linguistics moves beyond royal archives and a narrowly literary vocabulary to the ordinary words of household life. (pp. 99–101.)

These comparisons reveal an important possibility for linguistic preservation: the vocabulary of courtyards and domestic life may retain elements of older forms independently of the history of elite written literature. Yet phonetic similarity between words from different periods does not automatically establish direct descent. Intermediate Prakrit, Apabhramsha, Avahattha, contact with neighbouring languages, or parallel development must be examined. The formal comparisons are preliminary evidence for future comprehensive etymological work, not final judgements on every word's origin.

Classifying Sound Changes

The author's list distinguishes examples of sound addition (agama), several phonetic alterations, and other transformations. Discussions of words such as orhna and kosia provide an opportunity to examine a language's phonetic history. The importance lies not merely in naming a formal change, but also in understanding how local pronunciations and usages of meaning become established through it. (pp. 99–102.)

The rigour of comparative method would nevertheless require, for every word, the definitive source reading, lexicon entry number, original meaning, region of Maithili pronunciation, attested use, possible intermediary form, and relevant regular sound laws. The book provides a substantial foundation of examples, but not equal detail on all these matters for each word. Both the limitation and the usefulness must be acknowledged. Future research might divide the pairs into three categories: established, probable, and unresolved.

Semantic Narrowing: From General to Particular

On page 103, discussing semantic narrowing, the author compares older dictionary meanings with present or restricted uses of such words as kasauni, kalhi, and kabar in Maithili. Explaining kasauni in relation to a particular preparation made with unripe mango is especially useful to the history of food culture. Differences in the temporal limits and uses of a time word such as kalhi illuminate subtle changes in linguistic meaning. These instances show the relation between semantics and folk culture.

Care is needed in evaluating these arguments. To conclude that an older meaning was broader and a modern one narrower, one must examine the actual range of meanings in the older lexicon and the several possible local meanings found in contemporary Maithili. A word may have a restricted sense in one dialect but retain a broad one in another. The author's examples should therefore be supplemented by modern regional dictionaries and records of spoken language.

Semantic Extension: Everyday Technology and New Uses

The author considers semantic broadening in the examples of kolhu, ganth, and rot. Kolhu may mean not only a machine of a particular kind but a wider range of implements for pressing different substances. The discussion of ganth traces a movement from a particular fastening in clothing to a broader sense of a knot. The comparison of the specific food item rot with its wider uses is also significant. These examples relate semantic change to the uses of objects, technology, and transformations in everyday life. (pp. 103–104.)

A particular strength of the study is its connection of semantics to the material world of society. A word's meaning is not a lifeless definition in a dictionary: it changes with an object's shape, the method of making it, eating practices, and economic technology. The examples suggest the possibility of separate historical glossaries of food vocabulary, agricultural implements, and domestic terminology.

The Limits of Engagement with Contemporary Research

Recent linguistic research on Hemachandra's Deshinamamala has reconsidered the internal diversity of the deshi category and the historical purposes of the tatsama–tadbhava–deshi distinction. Andrea Drocco's work places this lexical classification in the context of medieval instruction in Prakrit and the understanding of word meanings. This more recent perspective is introduced not to alter Yoganand Jha's original essay but to recognize the present relevance of its questions. Comparison of older words with modern Maithili forms matters, but the lexicon's label “deshi” should not be regarded as a birth certificate proving derivation from a single historical language. (External research: Andrea Drocco, Kervan, DOI 10.13135/1825-263X/11454.)

A further caution applies: published editions of the historical lexicon, manuscript readings, and decisions by different editors cannot be assumed identical. A new collation of every word pair against contemporary critical

editions would be a proper task for future research. Unclear entry numbers or illegible forms in the source have not been "repaired" by conjecture in this review.

Overall Assessment

The volume's research orientation assumes its most concrete form in the final essay. Comparing the historical material of a classified dictionary with living Maithili words is a valuable methodological initiative. Yet the success of such comparison depends not on the quantity of similar-looking words but on the quality of historical verification for each pair. "Deshinamamala and Maithili" should thus be read as an initial research map for building a substantial evidence catalogue. Its most durable achievement is the impetus it gives to the future compilation of a systematic etymological dictionary.

An Integrated Critical Assessment of the Collection

A Connecting Thread from Folklore to Linguistics

Read in sequence, the nine essays reveal a coherent intellectual concern. The first identifies modes of collective oral expression; the essay on the Mallah community uncovers experience preserved in occupational speech; the essays on Radha, Parvati, and Suman show cultural meanings taking literary form; the essay on fiction links everyday speech to modern artistic prose; and the final linguistic essays examine changes in the forms of words across time. Across these three fields, one question continually recurs: to what extent can language preserve social memory?

In its treatment of folklore, the author advocates independent recognition of literature's folk component. Yet in evaluating poetry he also employs traditional concepts of rasa and the taxonomy of heroines. This duality is not merely a contradiction: it is an effort to use two traditions of knowledge together in a multilayered literary culture. Still, when folk literature is declared free of classical constraints while the literary discussion of women becomes wholly enclosed in classical categories, a methodological unevenness emerges. The reader needs to recognize it.

Field-Based and Text-Based Evidence

The first two essays chiefly employ oral material, social vocabulary, and proverbs. The three on poetry privilege textual quotation, the opinions of literary authorities, and arguments based on ornament and rasa. The essay on Amarji raises questions of historical documentation. The last two concentrate on dictionaries, etymology, and comparative linguistics. The diversity of material demonstrates the breadth of the author's research interests; it also demands care in distinguishing methods of establishing evidence. An oral proverb, a poetic verse, a publication year, and a dictionary entry are not facts of the same kind or subject to identical modes of verification.

An additional link in the argument is particularly necessary where a proverb is treated as proof of an ancient occupation, a heroine-type as the definitive description of a poetic character, or verbal similarity as proof of

historical continuity. This review's criticism is directed not against the original evidence but against leaps from evidence to categorical conclusions. Maintaining that distinction permits a fair appraisal of the collection.

Achievements in Social Criticism

The Mallah community, ill-matched marriages, the household of the poor, women's work, class in journalism, the language of Dalit characters, and the recognition of colloquial speech suggest that the author's literary view is not exclusively aesthetic. He also understands literature as a record of social relationships. There is a clear intellectual connection among Parvati's economic hardships, Amarji's sense of journalism's social usefulness, and the insistence that a fictional character's language be socially appropriate. This is one of the collection's distinctive strengths.

On the other hand, in some essays the tendency to elevate women as self-sacrificing wives or ideal mothers remains unexamined. More attention might also have been devoted to the mockery embedded in caste-based proverbs and the possibility that demands for linguistic purity marginalize lived multilingual experience. The evidence assembled by the author provides ample grounds for these questions. A contemporary rereading is not a repudiation of the original book but an expansion of its study.

Language, Style, and Critical Voice

The author's language is predominantly scholarly Maithili rich in Sanskrit-derived vocabulary. Folk expressions, idioms, snippets of song, and regional terms intervene vividly within this learned current. His sentences characteristically move from definition to example, earlier opinion, comparison, and conclusion, so the direction of his critical argument is usually clear. At certain points an abundance of quotations and classical terminology requires close attention to arrive at the central judgement. Even so, the author expects serious study of his readers: he offers research-based examination rather than popular introduction.

The book's organization is itself open to criticism. The foreword makes the essays comprehensible by grouping them in three thematic categories. The contents progress from folk life to literary poetry and then to the study of vocabulary and language. Yet, because no separate editorial afterword brings the nine essays together, readers must reconstruct their connecting thread themselves. The integrated comparison in this review is intended not to insert imaginary arguments into the gaps of the source but to elucidate connections among the examples actually presented.

An Itemized Evaluation of Achievements

The major accomplishment of “Maithili Folk Literature” is its broad framework of oral genres; “The Mallah Community in Proverbs” explores the connection between occupational life and linguistic metaphor; “The Character of Radha” insists on multiple interpretations; “The Character of Parvati” recognizes the realities of Maithil domestic life in a mythological figure; “Women in Suman's Muktaka Poetry” offers a classified reading of

poetic form and images of women; the review of Amarji identifies methodological and documentary problems in the history of journalism; the essay on fiction outlines developments in narrative craft and language; "The Concept of Deshi Words" teaches caution about etymological certainty; and the study of Deshinamamala connects lexicographic evidence with living Maithili forms. Each assessment is grounded in the argument of the relevant original essay or in its critical reappraisal here.

Directions for Future Research

Four research undertakings clearly emerge from this collection. First, renewed documentation of each collected folk song, epic, and proverb, recording location, informant, occasion, variant text, and audio. Second, separate comparative lists of original texts, variants, and social contexts of poetic passages cited from Vidyapati and Suman. Third, renewed verification of original available issues, editorial details, publication periods, and library holdings for each journal discussed by Amarji. Fourth, word-by-word examination from multiple sources of the dictionary readings in Deshinamamala and the linguistic forms of modern Maithili. All four proposals grow from the book's directly available material; none depends on conjecturing unknown or imagined chapters.

Final Conclusion

A Collection of Essays is distinctive not for offering one definitive theory, but for its dedication to gathering evidence and developing methods of analysis across the many fields of Maithili language and literary study. Its subjects are extensive, but the underlying demand is singular: Maithili's literary and social experiences must be recognized as materials for systematic research. The classification of folk genres, occupational contexts of proverbs, readings of Vidyapati's characters, Suman's conception of women, the history of journalism, the development of narrative prose, and historical changes in vocabulary together constitute a multidimensional portrait of Maithili studies.

Alongside this range are clear limitations: insufficient field information for oral sources, the need for independent archival corroboration of some historical claims, conventional idealizations of women, and the requirement for additional sound laws when drawing conclusions from resemblances between lexical forms. Identifying these limits does not belittle the book; it establishes its actual academic significance. The enduring strength of a scholarly volume lies not only in answers provided in its own time but also in the questions it generates for later inquiry. In this sense A Collection of Essays is both a valuable reference and a critical document worthy of rereading.

CHAPTER 04 / Second Edition, 2002

Maithili Shakta Literature

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

1. Introduction to the Book and the State of the Evidence

Original title: Maithili Shakta Sahitya (Shastriya Bhagavati Git)—Maithili Shakta Literature (Classical Songs to the Goddess).

Edited by Dr Yoganand Jha; the title page mentions Kabilpur, Darbhanga, alongside the editor's name.

Publication: Urvashi Prakashan, 13 MIG, Hanuman Nagar, Kankarbagh, Patna–20. The original publication details print the year 2002, a print run of 500, and a price of Rs 15.00 (reproduction p. 3, left-hand panel).

Edition: the close of the preface clearly states “second edition” and bears the date 7 November 2002 (reproduction p. 4, left-hand panel).

The opening cover, title page, publication details, preface, index of songs, and the texts printed on pages 10–72 are included; the final page also displays a mark indicating the book's end.

Two different sequences: the index of songs contains 76 author entries (reproduction pp. 4–6). The actual texts independently number the songs from (1) through (191); the last song is by Jagatchandra (reproduction p. 38). It would therefore be factually incorrect to describe the volume as containing “76 songs”: there are 76 index entries and 191 individually numbered songs.

Method of study: the title or opening line and printed page location of every author entry were checked against the original index. Close readings of representative songs attend to characteristic forms of address, images, philosophical vocabulary, supplication, compassion, and social questions. Where the textual reading is difficult or indistinct, exact quotation has been avoided.

2. The Preface: The Editor's Intellectual Proposition

The preface to the first edition regards “the worship of Shakti” as an important component of Indian life. According to the editor, different experiences of motherhood, compassion, creativity, preservation, and destruction find literary expression in the goddess's various forms (reproduction pp. 3–4). The preface is not merely an endorsement of religious belief; it also establishes an aesthetic basis for the study of Shakta poetry, because the diversity of divine forms gives rise to diversity in metaphor, symbolism, and aesthetic feeling.

The preface names Vidya, Durga, Kali, Chandi, Tara, Bhuvaneshwari, Kamala, Shodashi, Bhairavi, Sita, Chhinnamasta, Dhumavati, Bangla, Matangi, and Saraswati, among other forms. The list shows that the editor

understands “Shakta” not in the narrow sense of hymns to Durga alone, but as part of a much wider goddess tradition. Precisely because of this breadth, however, the collection's inclusion of the Ganga, Bharati, the veena-playing goddess, and images connected with Shiva calls for separate examination.

After naming medieval poets, the editor provides a long list of modern poets and songwriters. The preface asserts a continuous literary tradition across time; nevertheless, this collection does not appear to supply a systematic evidentiary table establishing the dates of poets, the composition dates of manuscripts, or variant readings. It is best regarded as a useful anthology for literary history, not a substitute for definitive chronological evidence.

In his note to the second edition, the editor describes the purpose of republication as making Maithili Shakta Literature more readily available and reaching more readers. This account makes the anthology's preservationist intention explicit. The motivation to republish is the direct statement of the preface, distinct from the printed details of the publication year and number of copies.

3. Editorial Structure: 76 Entries and 191 Songs

The book's central structural feature is that its contents are arranged by “author and song”, whereas the main texts possess their own numbering. Vidyapati, for example, appears as one entry in the contents, but several different compositions appear beneath his name on pages 10–13, marked with numbers beginning at (1). The first of Vidyapati's songs invokes Bhairavi, followed by songs to other forms of the goddess. The arrangement conveniently allows the several forms of a single poet's Shakta expression to be read together.

The closing section is especially meaningful: such names as Jagajjyotirmalla, Jagatprakashamalla, Jitamitra Malla, Bhupatindra Malla, Pratap Malla, and Jagatchandra appear together (index entries 71–76; printed pp. 67–72). The study of Maithili Shakta songs therefore also includes texts associated with Nepal's courtly literary tradition. Yet it would be inappropriate to derive each writer's detailed royal biography, period, or family relationships solely from the surname “Malla”; independent historical evidence would be necessary.

Below the songs, there are occasional source indications, including “Ancient Songs”, “Maithil Bhakta Prakash”, “Maithili Shaiva Literature”, “The Origin and Development of Maithili Drama”, and other works. These are important clues, but the collection does not give, with equal consistency for every song, its editorial transmission history, exemplar, edition number, and variant readings. The review identifies this as a task for future scholarly editing.

4. Close Readings of Representative Songs

4.1 Vidyapati: Bhairavi's Terror and Maternal Protection (printed pp. 10–13)

The opening song, "Jaya Jaya Bhairavi Asura-Bhayauni", combines an address to the goddess in her terrifying form with the worshipper's desire to be freed from fear. Images of the cremation ground, skull-bowl, blood, and destruction of demons evoke her fierce aspect; near the end, the poet's request for protection transforms this terror into compassionate refuge. She is the terror of demons but grants fearlessness to her devotee. Through this apparently contrary pairing, the composition becomes not merely praise but a dramatic experience of fear and trust.

4.2 Vidyapati: One Goddess, Many Names (pp. 10–13)

In the Vidyapati group, successive invocations of Bhairavi, Gayatri, Bhagavati, Kali, Durga, Kalika, and other names appear (the opening pages of the songs). Within one poet's work, the destructive and nurturing goddess, formulaic invocations and intimate addresses, alternate continually. The epithet "classical" in the title is grounded here in the Sanskritized naming tradition and litanies of divine epithets; accessible expressions of supplication, however, prevent the language from becoming an inert sequence of hymns.

4.3 Sadananda: A Direct Prayer for the Removal of Suffering (p. 14)

The first line of "Jaya Jaya Durge Durgati Harini" plainly relates Durga's name to durgati, misfortune, through sound. The name itself gathers the sense of the deity as remover of the devotee's suffering. The language is at points classical, but the emotional centre is relief from everyday adversity. In this manner, Shakta literature moves from philosophical substance towards the pain of ordinary life.

4.4 Mahesh Thakur: The Tension between Ferocity and Mercy (pp. 15–16)

In the song beginning "Jaya Jaya Jaya Bhaya Bhanjani", the goddess's power to dispel fear predominates. In other songs by this author, demon-slaying, fearful manifestations, and deliverance of those seeking refuge are brought together within a single hymn. Shakta praise here does not become a one-sided depiction of violence; it acquires the devotee-centred force of a vision of compassion.

4.5 Krishnapati and Jivadatta: The Grammar of Surrender (pp. 17, 19)

Opening lines such as "Shankari Sharanam Dhayal Ham Tor" and "Jaya Jaya Shankari" reveal the importance of the relation between "I" and "yours" in Shakta songs. The worshipper acknowledges weakness and addresses the goddess as the one responsible for protection. Through this language of intimacy, a classical goddess becomes the centre of ordinary people's faith.

4.6 Ratnapani: An Extended Chain of Names and Praise (pp. 26–31)

Ratnapani's entry extends across more than five printed pages. In the index, recurrent openings such as "Jaya Jagajanani", "Jaya Shishudhanu", "Jaya Bhuvaneshi", and "Jaya Jagajjanani" accompany invocations of the goddess's

many forms. Compared with other short hymns, the section resembles an expanded devotional sequence. Repeated "jaya" certainly suggests a rhythmic pattern, but the actual rhythm of performance cannot be established without musical evidence.

4.7 Chanda Jha: Surrender and Life's Distress (pp. 34–38)

Because the section begins several songs with lines such as "Jaya Devi Mahesh-Putri", "Rahu Devi Dasi", and "Jaya Girivar Maiya", it combines personal devotion with formal praise of the goddess. On pages 34–35, supplications such as "Se Kar Devi Dayamayi" and references to the condition of the "mind" are notable. The worshipper surrenders but does not abandon the language of suffering; the conjunction of classical divine names and familiar forms of address gives the poetry particular strength.

4.8 Adinath: The Expanding Litany of Divine Names (pp. 40–50)

Adinath's entry is a substantial cluster of texts. The index brings together different openings, among them "Nahi Jagabahar Ham", "Bhagavati Pada Pankaja", "Kali Tarini", and "Mahima Vasan Arun". References to the body, world, demons, Kamala, and the three realms combine multiple religious registers. The sheer extent of the vocabulary does not, however, establish an equally extensive theological system: the context in which each expression occurs must be understood.

4.9 Tejnath Jha: Moral Questions and Classical Devotion (pp. 52–54)

Openings such as "Janani Pada", "Jaya Jaya Kali", and "Gange Vinati Suniya Daya Kan" suggest the coexistence of maternal grace and moral helplessness in Tejnath Jha's compositions. Page 54 raises questions of social vanity and lack of knowledge. The work therefore speaks not only in the language of worship but also of self-examination. Its capacity to question even while surrendering gives it critical importance.

4.10 Surdas, Damodar, and Lakshmipati: From Guilt to Forgiveness (pp. 54–55)

The proximity of Surdas's "Jagadamba Bhavani He", Damodar's "Jaga Janani He", and Lakshmipati's "Kshama Samudra Kshamiya Aba Janani" forms a meaningful brief sequence. The first invokes the goddess as universal mother, the second voices the plight of a distressed devotee, and the third seeks refuge in the forgiving goddess. In these short songs, the distance between admission of guilt and hoped-for deliverance creates emotional intensity.

4.11 Laliteshwari Devi and Nandani Devi: The Presence of Women's Voices (pp. 55–56)

The index prints Laliteshwari Devi's "Jayati Jagadambike Kali" and Nandani Devi's "Jaya Kali Kali Kalusha". Laliteshwari's song contains, alongside worship of Jagadambika, a self-reproach resembling "I have performed neither worship and prayer, Mother, nor service to my teacher" (reproduction p. 29, right-hand panel). The presence of women poets shows that this tradition is not restricted to men's literary activity. It would,

however, be unsound to infer the literacy rates of an entire period from these names alone.

4.12 Surendra Jha Suman and Madhup: The Effect of Imagery (pp. 56, 58)

The image in Surendra Jha Suman's "Dhayal Mundamayi Shyama" offers a sculptural conception of the fierce goddess. Madhup's image of radiance in "Samprati Sahas-Surya Rajaya Jagamag Ma" evokes a shining manifestation of power. On one side is a fearsome scene; on the other, brilliance. Each conveys the goddess's limitless strength through a different sensory device.

4.13 Rajlakshmi and Trilochan Jha: Worship and the Sense of Mithila (pp. 62–63)

The intimacy of worshipping the goddess's feet is evident in Rajlakshmi's "Shyama Charana Kamala Ham Pujab". Trilochan Jha's "Chandi Tohar Mithila Desh, Aba Karu Jaju Deri" explicitly addresses the goddess within local geography. Such localization brings a classical deity into Maithili's social landscape: Mithila is not merely a geographical name but a field of experienced danger and hope.

4.14 R. C. Prasad Singh: Reconfiguring the Image of Saraswati (p. 64)

The address "Janani, Vina-Vadini!" foregrounds Saraswati through her instrument, voice, and learning. This example raises a question about the bounds of "Shakta literature": the collection's understanding of Shakti is not restricted to a battle goddess but extends to speech, knowledge, and creative energy. It would therefore be inadequate to call this merely an anthology of Durga songs.

4.15 Prabhu Narayan "Pradip": The Dramatic Use of Questioning (p. 65)

The recurring question "Jagadamba, ahi binu ashraya kakar?" places the helplessness of the vulnerable human being alongside praise of the goddess. The poet turns the poverty of the "I" into dependence upon the goddess. Here "to whom?" is not a request for factual information but a rhetorical question that creates devotional drama.

4.16 The Final Malla Group: A Textual Tradition Beyond Political Borders (pp. 67–72)

From Jagajjyotirmalla to Jagatchandra, the anthology closes with songs by writers whose names are associated with Nepal. Bhupatindra Malla's "Jaya Himalaya Nandini" addresses the goddess through the geography of the Himalayas; Pratap Malla's "Kidahu Karam Mor Hin Re" opens a voice of remorse; and Jagatchandra's final "Jayati Jagadambe Kali" is a brief hymn. Its source note, "The Origin and Development of Maithili Drama", deserves notice, but does not in itself establish the date of composition.

5. Language, Imagery, Rhythm, and the Rhetoric of Devotion

The most conspicuous rhetorical device in these songs is repeated address: "jaya jaya", "janani", "ma", "he devi", "Bhavani", "Kali", "Durga". This creates an enduring potential for singing and collective utterance. Yet the

collection does not appear to record ragas, talas, indications of tune, or performance evidence systematically. It would therefore be unsupported to claim that a particular song was certainly performed in a specified raga.

At one level, the language contains Sanskritized compounds —"tribhuvana-tarini", "Mahishasura-mardini", "bhaya-bhanjani", "jagajjanani", "kamalasini". At another, it has intimate Maithili pronouns and verbs—"ham", "tor", "dia", "karu", "ahan", "maiya". At a third are Tantric and Puranic nouns: spear, sword, skull-bowl, trident, blood, severed heads, lion, buffalo. These layers do not oppose one another; together they form the anthology's linguistic architecture.

Images of the trident, lion, lotus, blood, garland of heads, and hand granting fearlessness dominate the figurative system. Through paired contraries—radiant and terrifying, compassionate and punitive, mother and warrior—the poets present the goddess's totality. It would be inappropriate to read descriptions of ferocious imagery as factual historical accounts of violence; their value is that of religious symbols in poetry.

The poetic speaker is often a helpless suppliant, but in some songs also asks questions: why suffering, when deliverance, where refuge? These questions turn praise into a dialogue rather than an empty repetition of divine commands or virtues. The cluster of terms "offence", "sorrow", "pardon", "refuge", and "feet" occupies the centre of this human drama.

6. Society, Women, Locality, and the Tensions of Devotion

The folk mother and the goddess's grandeur: mother-centred devotion embodies a particular ethical imagination of power. Before the omnipotent goddess stands a devotee like a helpless child. Appeals for grace are therefore more frequently heard than commands. When the poet admits wrongdoing, this may express not only religious guilt but also a language of social abasement. That is a text-based interpretation, not a factual account of each poet's personal life.

The presence of women: the index contains author names including "Bhairani Devi", "Laliteshwari Devi", "Nandani Devi", and "Rajlakshmi". Recognizing these names is essential, because Shakta poetry is not simply men's accounts of female divinity; it also opens a space for women's poetic voices. Yet names alone cannot give a full picture of these poets' social lives, education, rights, or historical connections. Separate biographical inquiry is needed.

Locality: reading together Trilochan Jha's "Mithila Desh", Chanda Jha's "Maiya", Tejnath Jha's "Gange", and the "Janani" of numerous poets makes it clear that the goddess is not detached from geographical, linguistic, and domestic life. Although the anthology is broadly classical, its poetic energy is continually sustained by local speech and regional experience.

The possibility of social criticism: when the devotee acknowledges ignorance, vanity, sin, adversity, and lack of refuge, the words may suggest

moral reflection and self-criticism. But treating every verse as a manifesto of political resistance or a definite social movement would go far beyond the source. The appropriate critical method is to say no more than the text allows.

7. The Anthology's Achievements and Editorial Limitations

First achievement: a broad selection of the Maithili tradition of Shakta lyrics, organized by poets, is made available in a compact anthology. With 76 index entries and 191 numbered internal songs, it forms a readable textual collection.

Second achievement: alongside familiar figures such as Vidyapati, it makes less frequently discussed poets available for the researcher's selection of texts and comparative study.

Third achievement: various forms of the goddess—Bhairavi, Durga, Kali, Kamala, Ganga, Saraswati, and Vina-Vadini—are placed within one broad experience of Shakta poetry.

Fourth achievement: many songs conclude with references to older source books. Though incomplete, these offer useful leads for research into their textual history.

Textual-critical limitation: manuscript sequences, editions of original sources, variant readings, principles of punctuation, evidence for dating poets, and editorial policies are not explained systematically.

Musicological limitation: lyrics are available, but the lack of ragas, talas, performance styles and contexts, traditions of singing, and audio documentation calls for restraint in musical conclusions.

Limitation of indexing: the contents are organized around authors. Without an index for individual songs, it is difficult to locate immediately where each of the 191 songs begins.

Historical limitation: the exact year of the first edition, the dates of song sources, the character of Nepal–Mithila contacts, biographies of women poets, and relationships among manuscript witnesses still require research.

Identifying these limitations does not diminish the book's significance. The first stage of literary preservation involves editing texts and making them available; a second requires scientific collation, annotation, musical documentation, glossaries, and chronology. This book is a notable undertaking of the first kind, while a critical edition of the second kind remains a task for future scholarship.

8. Sequential Notes on the 76 Entries in the Index of Songs

The following list follows the order of the original “Index of Songs” (reproduction pp. 4–6). The “Opening/Indication” gives only the first line or an identifying phrase of a song or song group; these are not separate numerical counts of every composition. Each note offers a brief critical indication based

on a title, opening words, or examination of the corresponding work. Where an author has multiple songs, the first or a representative one is listed.

01. Vidyapati (printed pp. 10–13)—"Jaya Jaya Bhairavi". A series of hymns beginning with Bhairavi and extending through Gayatri, Kali, Durga, and other forms; the tension between terror and fearlessness predominates.

02. Lakhanchand (printed p. 14)—"Namo Namo Chandi". Repeated salutations lend the opening the quality of mantra recitation; the goddess's feet become a place of refuge.

03. Chaturanan (printed p. 14)—"Jayamandala Jayamandala". Durga's victorious image in a mandala-centred hymn; the rhythm of repetition is important.

04. Sadananda (printed p. 14)—"Jaya Jaya Durge Durgati". The phonetic resemblance between her name and her function presents the goddess as remover of distress.

05. Maharaja Mahesh Thakur (printed pp. 15–16)—"Jaya Jaya Jaya Bhaya Bhanjani". A composite image of dispelling fear, slaying Mahisha, and protecting devotees.

06. Maharaja Mahinath Thakur (printed p. 16)—"Vadana Bhayana Kana". Description moves between the goddess's fierce countenance and the worshipper's astonishment.

07. Lochan (printed p. 16)—"Jaya Jaya Jaya Nata Satata". The mood of a bowed head and an abbreviated form of uninterrupted veneration.

08. Krishnapati (printed p. 17)—"Shankari Sharanam Dhayal Ham Tor". The phrase "I am yours" creates a personal relationship born of surrender.

09. Manganiram (printed p. 17)—"Tohi Dharani Tohi Karani". The same goddess is seen as the power of creation and action.

10. Shambhudatta (printed p. 17)—"Jaya Jaya Adi Shakti". A concise philosophical affirmation of the primal power of the universe.

11. Shankar (printed p. 18)—"Girinandini Shubha Dina". The image of the mountain's daughter accompanies a prayer for auspiciousness.

12. Jivadatta (printed p. 19)—"Jaya Jaya Shankari". Praise of the goddess associated with Shiva; repeated sounds are effective.

13. Vangishwar (printed pp. 19–20)—"Jaya Jaya Triguna". Philosophical reference to the three gunas opens the goddess's universal form.

14. Shrikantaganak (printed p. 20)—"Jaya Jaya Bhagavati Jaya". Direct address and reiterated attributes create a singable form of praise.

15. Ramnath (printed p. 21)—"Je Je Je Bhavasagara Tarini". The symbolism of liberation from the ocean of existence connects Vaishnava and Shakta imagery.

16. Devanath (printed p. 21)—"Nila Vasani Shambhu Dharani". The colour of clothing and association with Shiva produce a visual portrayal.

17. Jayakrishna (printed p. 22)—"Jai Kalike Svargadharini". The fierce Kali is joined with the task of sustaining the celestial realm.

18. Ramdas (printed p. 22)—"Pranamao Pranata Kalpataru". The wish-fulfilling tree becomes a metaphor for the goddess as fulfiller of desires.

19. Saheb Ramdas (printed p. 22)—"Janakalloli Mahima". A plea connecting remembrance and divine greatness within a restless mind.

20. Govinddas (printed p. 23)—"Jayati Jaya Vrishabhanu". Symbols associated with the bull evoke the divine family's background in the hymn.

21. Umapati (printed p. 23)—"Jaya Jaya Madhukaitabha Mardini". The memory of slaying Madhu and Kaitabha is linked with the tradition of the goddess who preserves creation.

22. Ramapati (printed p. 24)—"Jaya Jaya Tribhuvana Tarini". The vast reach of the goddess who delivers all three worlds.

23. Lalkavi (printed p. 25)—"Jaya Hariramani". A name associated with Hari shows the flexibility of sectarian boundaries in devotional language.

24. Devanand (printed p. 25)—"Jaya Jaya Durga". In this short hymn, Durga's name becomes the centre of rhythm and reverence.

25. Gokulanand (printed p. 25)—"Jaya Jaya Bharati Bhagavati". The power of Bharati's speech is included within the Shakta domain.

26. Kaharam (printed p. 26)—"Jaya Jaya Durga Durgi, Jai Jai Kamala". The paired invocation of Durga and Kamala displays the diversity of divine forms.

27. Ratnapani (printed pp. 26–31)—"Jaya Jagajanani". An extensive group of songs, a chain of hymns to the Mother, Bhuvaneshi, Kamala, and Durga.

28. Bhanunath (printed p. 32)—"Jaya Jaya Tribhuvana". An announcement of the goddess's power across the three worlds.

29. Harshanath (printed pp. 32–33)—"Jaya Jaya Kumati Vinashini". Removal of wrong thinking alongside suffering connects power with understanding.

30. Chanda Jha (printed pp. 34–38)—"Jaya Devi Mahesh-Putri". A lengthy section of servitude, compassion, maternal address, and anxious appeals for welfare.

31. Kanhadas (printed p. 38)—"Jaya Gangaji". The goddess form of the Ganga extends the Shakta category to river worship.

32. Jaladhardas (printed p. 38)—"Janani! Aba Janu". An urgent appeal to the Mother to recognize the speaker's present suffering.

33. Das (printed p. 39)—"Ja Ke Pir Hare". The removal of pain becomes the song's central expectation.

34. Chiranjeev (printed p. 39)—"Jaya Kali Jaya Tara". Parallel invocations of Kali and Tara reveal the multiplicity of Tantric goddesses.

35. Narasinghdatta (printed p. 39)—"Durgi Lekha Daya-Daya Tor". Repeated appeals for compassion make the voice of the humble supplicant central.

36. Shravan Singh (printed p. 40)—"Jaya Kamalanayani Kamala". The gentleness of lotus imagery counterbalances the goddess's fierce forms.

37. Bhairani Devi (printed p. 40)—"Jaya Jaya Durga Anupama Rupe". The name suggests a woman's poetic voice addressing Durga in incomparable beauty.

38. Adinath (printed pp. 40–50)—"Nahi Jagabahar Ham". One of the longest sections, containing numerous divine names, images, and songs of surrender.

39. Durgadatta Singh (printed p. 50)—"Tua Pade Kamala Santata". The mind's unbroken attachment to the lotus feet of the goddess.

40. Dinabandhu Jha (printed p. 51)—"Jayati Bhagavati Bhakta-Tarini". The duality of saving devotees, a fearsome appearance, and compassionate power.

41. Jivan Jha (printed p. 52)—"Dina Puna Pherahu Bhuvaneshi". An urgent hope that adverse circumstances may be changed for the better.

42. Tejnath Jha (printed pp. 52–54)—"Jagata Janani Pada". Moral self-examination through the World Mother's feet and invocations of Kali and the Ganga.

43. Surdas (printed p. 54)—"Jagadamba Bhavani He". Simplicity of maternal invocation, with poverty and hope at its centre.

44. Damodar (printed p. 54)—"Jaga Janani He". Calling the goddess to awaken is a gesture seeking her attention.

45. Lakshmipati (printed p. 54)—"Kshama Samudra Kshamiya Aba Janani". The ocean of pardon soothes a confessed sense of guilt.

46. Yadunath Mishra (printed p. 55)—"Daityon Damana". The memory of ferocity alongside the story of suppressing demons.

47. Laliteshwari Devi (printed p. 55)—"Jayati Jagadambike Kali". A remembrance of compassionate Kali with self-reproach for insufficient worship.

48. Nandani Devi (printed p. 55)—"Jaya Kali Kali Kalusha". The impurity of the age of Kali and the goddess's purifying power resonate together.

49. Jivanand (printed p. 56)—"Jaya Jaya Bhavajanani". The primordial maternal form of existence and the energy of repeated address.

50. Surendra Jha "Suman" (printed p. 56)—"Dhayal Mundamayi Shyama". The fierce sculptural image provides the poem's visual appeal.

51. Ishanath Jha (printed p. 57)—"Jaya Jaya Durge Dalani". Destructive force joins the direct address of a devotee.

52. Madhup (printed p. 58)—“Samprati Sahas-Surya Rajaya Jagamag Ma”. The image of a thousand suns expands the goddess's limitless brilliance.

53. Shrikrishna (printed p. 59)—“Jaya Jaya Janani”. A brief hymn to the Mother constructed around repetition.

54. Vishwanath (printed p. 60)—“Jaya Jaya Sakala Asura”. The remembrance of victory establishes the goddess's courage.

55. Maharaja Rameshwar Singh (printed p. 60)—“Jaya Jaya Jagajanani, Ki Kahab Janani”. The inability to express her greatness reveals its boundlessness.

56. Shivadatta (printed p. 61)—“Brahmashakti Je Chahiya Aili”. The word “Brahmashakti” gives worship a philosophical horizon.

57. Tannath Jha (printed p. 61)—“Singha Charhal Mata”. A folk image of the lion-riding Mother and the overcoming of fear.

58. Yadunath Jha “Yaduvar” (printed p. 62)—“Mandalamaya Maithila”. The goddess's power conjoined with Maithili cultural vocabulary.

59. Rishinath Jha (printed p. 62)—“Janani Tanaya Vinaya”. A request for forgiveness through the relationship between mother and child.

60. Rajlakshmi (printed p. 62)—“Shyama Charana Kamala Ham Pujab”. Service at the divine feet and intimate devotion come together.

61. Trilochan Jha (printed pp. 62–63)—“Chandi Tohar Mithila Desh”. A rare voice directly inviting the goddess into Mithila's society and geography.

62. Gananath (printed p. 63)—“Akatha Tattva Tua Tarini”. The relationship between ineffable divine power and deliverance.

63. Shyamanand Jha (printed p. 64)—“Jaya Kamalasini”. The tranquil lotus-seated form broadens the goddess's diverse manifestations.

64. R. C. Prasad Singh (printed p. 64)—“Janani, Vina-Vadini!”. Knowledge, speech, and the veena suggest Saraswati within an expanded Shakta meaning.

65. Kanchinath Jha “Kiran” (printed p. 64)—“Janani! Lia Aba Sudhi”. The immediate appeal of a suffering devotee awaiting recognition.

66. Chandrabhanu Singh (printed p. 65)—“Janani Tohar Charana”. Closeness to the goddess's feet as a devotional goal and psychological reassurance.

67. Prabhu Narayan “Pradip” (printed p. 65)—“Jagadamba Ahi”. Repeatedly asking “To whom may I turn but you?” brings drama into the hymn.

68. Chandramani (printed p. 65)—“Jayati Bhavani”. A desire for protection within a concise cry of victory.

69. Chandrakant Jha (printed p. 66)—“Jagu Jagu Maiya”. The metaphor of waking the goddess is, in reality, a plea for her to notice people's suffering.

70. Unknown Poet (printed p. 67)—“Song Text (Author Unspecified)”. The writer remains unidentified; it would be improper to fill the absence of evidence with an invented biography.

71. Jagajjyotirmalla (printed pp. 67–68)—"Madhukaitabha Mahishasura Maral". A hymn pairing Puranic demon-slaying with maternal power.

72. Jagatprakashamalla (printed pp. 69–70)—"Nahi Ana Gati Hamara". The goddess as sole refuge, in a sequence of confessed guilt and appeals for compassion.

73. Jitamitra Malla (printed p. 70)—"Namo Rudrani Giritanaya". Two names together invoke Rudrani, associated with Shiva, and the mountain's daughter.

74. Bhupatindra Malla (printed p. 71)—"Jaya Himalaya Nandini". Himalayan imagery suggests the goddess's lofty glory and cultural geography.

75. Pratap Malla (printed p. 72)—"Kidahu Karam Mor Hin Re". A supplicatory verse of remorse, actions, and grace: confession rather than mere recitation.

76. Jagatchandra (printed p. 72)—"Jayati Jagadambe Kali". In the closing song, the victory of Kalika and refuge form a concise ending.

9. Critical Conclusion

The value of Maithili Shakta Literature does not reside simply in its being a collection of songs to the goddess; its distinction is the conjunction of authors from differing periods, styles, and linguistic registers. Across 76 author entries and 191 songs, the goddess appears now as destroyer of demons, now as an ocean of forgiveness, now as giver of knowledge, and now as the folk mother of Mithila. This multiplicity makes the book a basis for an integrated study of Mithila's religious imagination, hymn structures, poetic language, and social feeling.

The editor's preface to the first edition offers the cultural and philosophical horizon of Shakta literature; his note to the second makes clear the desire to spread the texts. Organization by poet is a convenient starting point for researchers. But a future critical edition would gain greatly from a separate index to all 191 songs, a full list of sources, textual variants, evidence for composition dates, a glossary of difficult words, and documentation of singing traditions.

Overall assessment of the book: it is an important anthology preserving Shakta poetry, not a definitive critical edition establishing the final texts. Its irreplaceable merit is the opportunity it provides to encounter many forms of the goddess, many poetic voices, and many kinds of supplicatory song in Maithili in one place. Readers need abandon neither faith nor critical judgement: keeping their methods distinct while bringing them together makes the anthology still more meaningful.

CHAPTER 05 / 2006

One Hundred Years of Maithili Journalism

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

The introductory preface entitled “Bhavya O Divya Prabha” is in Maithili, but from printed page 17 onward the principal historical discussion is written predominantly in Hindi. This linguistic distinction is an important research fact. The original account is examined in Maithili in the source review, without misrepresenting the language of the original discussion as Maithili. The author's Hindi exposition, Maithili quotations, periodical titles, and dates are distinguished from one another. Where the original text contains internal inconsistencies or differs from external sources, these are described as matters requiring examination, not as definitively established truths.

2. The Book's Central Argument: A Century of Achievement and an Incomplete Public Life

Yoganand Jha's central thesis develops between two contrasting facts. First, during a hundred years of Maithili journalism, numerous literary journals, monthlies, weeklies, handwritten newsletters, children's magazines, research journals, souvenirs, and daily newspapers were published. They provided important foundations for modern Maithili literature, linguistic consciousness, script, orthography, drama, fiction, poetry, and criticism. Second, the expansion of periodicals did not produce an equivalent expansion in sustainable news provision, broad readership, regular distribution, commercial revenue, and direct engagement with everyday life. At the centre of the author's final assessment lies the difference between “literary journalism” and “journalism”. (Printed pp. 18–19, 62–64.)

This tension can be considered the book's principal intellectual achievement. The author does not simply enumerate journals; he asks whether they could carry society's everyday problems, information, education, economics, and public debate. Yet by treating the daily newspaper as virtually the highest test of “successful journalism”, he sometimes undervalues the achievements of literary, intellectual, community, and little magazines. The following sections of the review examine that tension.

3. The Book's Organization and Authorial Voice

The book is not divided into conventionally numbered chapters; it develops as an extended historical essay under thematic headings. Printed pages 5–16 offer an intimate Maithili preface, memories of literary relationships, Pandit Surendra Jha “Suman”'s contribution, and events connected with language activism. Pages 17–19 introduce the historical beginnings of journalism and its overall assessment; pages 19–23 treat Swadesh and Mithila Mihir Daily under “Daily Newspapers”; pages 23–54 provide extensive descriptions under “Other Journals and Periodicals”; pages 54–55 cover “Maithili Periodicals in Nepal”;

pages 55–56, “Handwritten Journals”; pages 56–62, “Present-Day Maithili Periodicals”; and pages 62–64, the conclusion.

In the opening preface the author recalls his memories, experience of seminars, association with Suman, opportunities to see issues of the daily Swadesh, and help from various editors and researchers. These details make the book not merely a secondary examination but an undertaking by a participant in the world of journalism itself. The author acknowledges that the selection depends on the periodicals available and that some rare or irregular publications may have been omitted. This admission should be understood as an honest limitation of the historiography, not evidence that the list is exhaustive. (Printed pp. 10–14.)

The extensive good wishes, dedication, personal gratitude, and reminiscences offer evidence of the book's cultural milieu; but a critical student of its historical essay should read those pages separately from the classification of source materials. Gratitude to individuals does not amount to independent verification of facts.

4. Imagining Journalism Before 1905: The Difference between Plans and Publication

At the start of the main discussion, the author mentions Ayodhya Prasad Khatri's plan for a journal called Tirhut and correspondence from 1901. According to his account, the proposed journal never appeared in print. Here the author makes the necessary distinction between a “planned periodical” and a “published periodical”. He points to early correspondence by referring to Ayodhya Prasad Khatri Smarak Granth and Amarji's Parichay Sansar O Patrachar. (Printed p. 17.)

The episode is useful in defining a historical starting year with care. An idea, announcement, or preparations for printing may belong to the institutional history of journalism, but should not be counted as a regularly published periodical without evidence of an actual first issue. Jha's choice of 1905 therefore marks the beginning of a tradition of published periodicals. The correspondence relating to Khatri's plan is known through sources cited within the book; copies of the original letters were not independently obtained for this review.

5. Maithil Hit Sadhan: Jaipur, Migration, and the Birth of a Printed Public Sphere

The author regards Maithil Hit Sadhan, published from Jaipur, as an early Maithili journal, identifying Vidyavachaspati Madhusudan Jha as a pioneering initiator. The book places education, the welfare of Maithil society, discussion of social evils, and the publication of works on grammar, mathematics, geography, history, and philosophy at the centre of the journal's aims. The publication of Maithil Charucharya is also discussed. (Printed pp. 17–18, 24.)

The historical significance is that the institution of Maithili journalism began not in the geographical centre of Mithila but in distant Jaipur through an association of migrant intellectuals. In building a linguistic community, the periodical was not only a medium of news but a means of connecting writers, readers, schools, associations, and publishers. An independent research abstract by Ripunjay Kumar Thakur on Maithil migration to Rajasthan and exchange of knowledge likewise discusses the Jaipur publication of 1905, Madhusudan Jha, and interregional connections. This external comparison supports the book's broad context, but the original cover of the first issue has not been independently examined in this review.

The author regards Maithil Hit Sadhan as a meaningful effort at social reform, while acknowledging its brief existence. The book does not supply figures for readership, monthly circulation, printing expenditure, or subscriptions. It cannot therefore sustain a specific statistical account of the financial reasons for closure.

6. Mithilamod: Mixed Languages, Editing, and Literary Expansion

According to the book, Mithilamod, published from Kashi, was an early pillar of Maithili journalism. It dates the journal's beginnings to Shravan Purnima in 1905 and names Murlidhar Jha and, later, Sitaram Jha and Upendranath Jha among its editors. The author states that in the early years it used Hindi and Maithili, later giving Maithili the larger place. Book publication, the introduction of writings by women, debates on orthography, Tirhuta, language rights, and social questions all emerged through it. (Printed pp. 24–25.)

The significant analytical fact is that the first world of print associated with language-making was not monolingual. The existence of a periodical mixing Maithili and Hindi neither invalidates its contribution nor establishes that it must be judged by the standards of later entirely Maithili publications. Language choice concerned the period, educated readers' habits, printing resources, and public purposes. The evidence supplied by the book is valuable here.

Sources differ over the journal's first year. Yoganand Jha gives 1905, as does a published list by Dr Dhanakar Thakur, while some other histories give 1906. It would be inappropriate to decide definitively between 1905 and 1906 simply by consulting a later list. The first issue, publication announcement, and contemporary advertisements require comparison.

7. Mithila Mihir: A Centre of Printing in Mithila and a Long-Lived Institution

Yoganand Jha dates the beginning of Mithila Mihir in Darbhanga to Makar Sankranti 1909. He describes its initially predominant Hindi content, Maithili's growing role, its transformation from a monthly into a weekly, the Mithilank special issue of 1936, and republication centred on Patna around 1960. According to the book, Vishnukant Jha, Parmeshwar Jha, Surendra Jha

"Suman", Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary, and several others were associated with its editorial work. (Printed pp. 25–26.)

The periodical's strength lies not only in its longevity but in its institutional transformations. A publication moved from monthly literary expression to weekly public discussion and ultimately a daily news structure. These changes provide a basis for understanding the relationships among local editing, publication capital, readers' expectations, and advertising. Read together, pages 25–26 and 22–23 transform the book's history from a list of individual periodicals into a study of the changing form of a medium.

External sources also disagree over Mithila Mihir's founding year: a Marathi encyclopaedia gives 1908, Dr Dhanakar Thakur's list gives 1909, and some Nepalese reviews give 1912. It is necessary to cite 1909 as the date stated by Yoganand Jha; establishing a definitive date requires direct evidence from the earliest issues. A date in one book does not automatically disprove another book's date.

8. The Daily Swadesh: From a Monthly in 1948 to a Historic Daily in 1955

Swadesh occupies a special place in Yoganand Jha's discussion. Pandit Surendra Jha "Suman" issued the monthly Swadesh in 1948; six issues are mentioned. According to the book, the daily edition began on 9 October 1955. Its four pages gave space to news, opinion, public questions, popular views, political commentary, household information, railway timetables, market prices, sport, and satire rather than primarily to literature. The author presents it as an early experiment in daily journalism in northern Bihar. (Printed pp. 19–21.)

The study of Swadesh is among the book's most detailed descriptions. The author discusses its physical format, columns, a maxim on the front page, the reader-letter section "Lokmat", the poem "Jaya Jaya Swadesh", and Chandranath Mishra "Amar"'s satirical writing. These details show that news was accompanied by political awareness, reader participation, and everyday practical information. To dismiss Swadesh merely as a sentimental experiment in writing in the mother tongue would therefore be unfair to the evidence the author supplies.

Caution is required concerning the end of this phase. Printed page 20 speaks of sixty-five issues through December 1955, but page 21 gives the date of closure differently. No single definitive date of the final issue is declared here. In the preface, the author also quotes Suman's report of 1957, which states that the daily was suspended because of financial losses. This testifies to financial instability, but is not an audited statement of income and expenditure. (Printed pp. 9, 20–21.)

9. Swadesh's Second Phase, 1981–1983: The Difficulties of Daily Publication

The book states that daily publication of Swadesh recommenced on 5 August 1981 and continued as an experiment through October 1983. During this phase, printing resources, the size and number of pages, and the regularity of publication were unstable. The author describes the coexistence of satire, mother-tongue commitment, everyday subjects, poetry, fiction, and public commentary, suggesting that the news-centred daily gradually reacquired the appearance of a literary magazine. (Printed pp. 21–22.)

The comparison of the two phases of Swadesh is a key to the book's theory of journalism. The name, editorial commitment, and background of language activism remained, but resources and social conditions had changed. A financially weak daily has an exceptionally difficult workflow: gathering content, printing regularly, distributing, editing, and attracting advertising must all be renewed day after day. Yoganand Jha reveals this practical crisis but does not provide precise costs, distribution areas, subscription percentages, or revenue per issue. The account is thus a strong qualitative study, not a quantitative economic history.

10. Mithila Mihir Daily: A Model of News Organization, 1984–1986

According to the book, Mithila Mihir appeared as a daily on 20 February 1984 and continued until June 1986. It benefited from publishing arrangements associated with Aryavarta and Indian Nation. The author considers its page layout, categories of news, editorials, political satire, additional Thursday and Sunday material, cinema, sport, horoscopes, literature, and annual issues. (Printed pp. 22–23.)

Compared with Swadesh's personal dedication, Mithila Mihir Daily possessed a different institutional strength. An established press, editorial organization, and links to multilingual news institutions could help sustain a daily publication. Yet the daily closed after a little more than two years. Its experience suggests that capital alone is insufficient: a readership market and sustainable economic arrangements are also necessary. Here economic factors are treated as possible causes; the source book does not present an audited and definitive account of the closure.

One important feature is that the author describes the external appearance, editorial practices, and specific columns of issues he had seen. Such passages approach direct examination of printed issues and have considerably greater evidential value than a list of titles. Future researchers could separately catalogue copies of these issues, dates, advertisement layouts, and printing statements.

11. The Years 1920–1940: Migrant Maithils, Writing in Maithili, and Literary Institutions

In discussing Maithili Prabha and Maithil Prabhakar, the author identifies the efforts of migrant Maithil groups in Ajmer, Agra, and Aligarh. He gives Shrimathili a special place as a completely Maithili-language periodical issued from Darbhanga. The editorial openness of Mithila, the fortnightly form of Mithila Mitra, the migrant connections of Maithil Bandhu, and the socially oriented roles of Maithil Yuvak and Jivan Prabha are distinguished. (Printed pp. 26–28.)

Three separate questions underlie this period's history: linguistic purity, social representation, and wider circulation. Describing Shrimathili as an early monolingual undertaking may be consequential for language history; it does not justify regarding earlier mixed-language journals as "less Maithili". Research into the transition would require examination of the proportions of languages in articles, advertisements, editorials, and readers' letters.

The discussion of Bharati, Vibhuti, and Maithili Sahitya Patra reveals differing models of the literary journal. Bharati was associated with university recognition and language activism; Vibhuti took a fearless but, in the author's view, controversial critical approach; under Ramanath Jha, Maithili Sahitya Patra organized material in a form resembling a book. (Printed pp. 28–29.) The harsh description "yellow journalism" expresses the author's definite judgement, but the absence of a comparative sample of particular passages or full issues limits its evidential basis.

12. The Years 1940–1960: Swadesh, Vaidehi, Children's Periodicals, and New Writing

Around the Second World War, the publications considered include Satya Sandesh, the monthly Swadesh of 1948, Mithila Jyoti, Pallav, Vaidehi, Mithila Darshan, Mithila Dut, and Nutan Vishva. For some the author records one or two issues; for others, achievements extending over decades. Pallav's rural place of publication and support for new writers, Vaidehi's long literary role, and Mithila Darshan's political campaign for language rights are particularly important. (Printed pp. 29–32.)

In the case of Vaidehi, the book describes different editors, changes of publication centre, special issues, and its continuation to approximately 1990. It can be understood as a workshop of modern Maithili writing where generations of authors, literary genres, and intellectual movements developed. Without a complete list of issues, however, the author's qualitative judgements of "excellence" or "decline" cannot safely be applied uniformly to every year.

The discussion of Batuk, Dhiyaputa, and Shishu demonstrates that Maithili journalism was not exclusively an intellectual field for adult writers. Specialized periodicals experimented with children's education, translation, character stories, early readers, and entertainment. The author describes different periods of Batuk, children's-literature special numbers, and

Dhiyaputa's emphasis on child psychology. He attributes limits on the development of readership partly to the unavailability of institutionalized education in the mother tongue. (Printed pp. 32–33.) This is an important sociological and educational hypothesis, but its verification would require independent data on schools, curricula, distribution, and reader response.

13. The Years 1960–1970: Agitation, Experiment, and the Expansion of Literary Debate

For the author, discussions of Ijot, Abhivyanjana, the weekly Mithila, Mithila Sevak, Maithili Sahitya Parishad Patrika, Abhiyan, Maithili Kavita, Maithili Prakash, Akhar, and Sonamati present varied experiments in literary journalism. Abhivyanjana became a forum for novelty and experimental writing; Maithili Kavita for selections of poetry; Maithili Prakash for scholarship; Akhar for new writing and language activism; Sonamati attempted to address several kinds of readerly interest. (Printed pp. 33–36.)

A history of genres is embedded within this classification. Creating separate forums for fiction, poetry, criticism, theatre, and linguistic awareness meant that editors were identifying distinct reading communities within a wider literary public sphere. The author sometimes regards this specialization as an achievement and sometimes as a departure from general news journalism. Considering both judgements reveals that "journalism" and the "little literary magazine" do not always have identical purposes, and should not always be measured by the same criteria.

14. The Years 1960–1980: Politics, Language Rights, and Ideological Journals

Accounts of Janak (edited by Chandranath Mishra "Amar"), Swadeshvani, Mithila Times, Charcha, Samad, Vikalp, Mithila Bhumi, Maithili Samachar, and other publications show that Maithili print culture also carried political ideas. Questions concerning the founding of a university, a radio centre, the right to take examinations in the mother tongue, the Constitution's Eighth Schedule, a separate state of Mithila, and partisan ideologies remained active in these journals. (Printed pp. 36–41.)

The author's perspective is most actively engaged, though sometimes uneven, here. He praises a periodical when it struggles for recognition of Maithili; when another is attached to a party or editorial opposition, he sometimes condemns it in terms of language or "yellow journalism". He describes Mithila Times as ideologically associated with the Communist Party, Charcha as Congress-supporting, and Nutan Vishva as connected with Ananda Marga. Ideological alignment is not, by itself, unethical journalism. Ethical assessment should instead be based on demonstrated factual inaccuracies, suppression of opposing opinion, unverified sources, malicious accusations, or deception of readers.

The discussion of Samad and Vikalp in 1978 is especially important. According to the author, the journals were used to oppose a governmental

decision concerning Maithili's place in the matriculation examination. Here print becomes an instrument for trying to change public policy. Yet the original book does not append the government notification, published editorials, and administrative records of any reversal. The sequence of events is thus a recorded claim within the book, not a complete documentary reconstruction.

15. "Mini-Magazines" and Little Magazines: Innovation in Small Formats

In discussing Mi., Anama–Kathadisha, Chadur, Sannipat, Agnipatra, Mahur, Bhumhur, Bhur, Shikha, Laldhuan, Sankalp, Akshat, Mithila Samuday, and Farak, the author records the history of new writing, opposition to convention, intellectual dissent, small formats, and irregular publication. Mi. is particularly notable for its miniature size. Fiction-centred projects such as Kathadisha suggest attempts to create a readership for a particular genre. (Printed pp. 42–44.)

The author detects individualism and irregularity in these small experiments. Some of his objections raise legitimate questions: how many issues did subscribers receive, was the promised frequency honoured, and how did the editorial institution function? But a single-issue journal is not historically worthless. One issue may shift the direction of a poetry movement, publish a play, or introduce a new author. Longevity and intellectual influence therefore need to be treated as independent measures.

From a critical perspective, the author places the little magazines of the 1970s at the centre of political and cultural struggles, but gives no systematic technical account of their means of circulation: cyclostyling, inexpensive printing, student unions, seminars, and poetry readings. This is an opportunity for further research.

16. The Years 1980–1990: Orthography, Women Editors, Progressive Literature, and Thematic Expansion

The book discusses the varied roles of Deskos, Videha, examples of women-edited periodicals, Mati-Pani, Kosi Kusum, Basat, Sandarbh, Chingi, Lokaved, Halchal, Bhakha, Kushalkshem, Ankhi-Pankhi, and other journals. Some attempted to combine literary writing with news, politics, and social debate; others served as forums specifically for criticism, new poetry, or progressive literature. (Printed pp. 45–48.)

The indications of women's editorship and women-centred subjects in this account are particularly noteworthy. The author discusses Videha and other periodicals supported by women. Nevertheless, he does not everywhere develop a separate and comprehensive history distinguishing women as writers, editors, publishers, printers, distributors, and readers. Merely listing women's participation differs from examining its institutional constraints. The actual contents, editorial decisions, and readers' letters of such publications would provide a clearer gender history of Maithili journalism.

For the author, Chingi's progressive debates, Lokaved's distinctive presentation and literary standards, Bhakha's movement from new writing to later literary forms, and Mati-Pani's combination of news and opinion represent different kinds of experiment. This does not imply that every journal had equal historical influence: the book evaluates them by differing criteria. A critic must continually distinguish an "editor's opinion" from the material actually published in the journal's issues.

17. The Years 1990–2005: Metropolitan Migration, Research Periodicals, and Multifaceted Editing

The book's later sections discuss Maithili Alochana, Chaturang, Mithila Parikrama, Mithila Samad, Janaki, Mithila Prakash, Kokil Manch, Akanksha, Maithili Times, Jaya Mithila, Mithila Surabhi, Bagmati Damodar Times, Antika, Deshaj, Desil Vayana, Ankur, Lorik Salhes Dinabhadri, Sutradhar, Bhorukava, and Pravasi. The list reveals an extensive network of Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai, Patna, Darbhanga, Saharsa, Madhubani, Dhanbad, and migrant associations. (Printed pp. 48–54.)

Many periodicals of the decade describe themselves as forums for "news and opinion", yet in the author's examination many issues remain chiefly vehicles of literature. Akanksha's attempt to include society, education, women's issues, health, and science; Antika's new publication design; Deshaj's specific discussions of poetry; Ankur's connections with migrants; and Sutradhar's attention to the Kosi region indicate distinct readerships. Such differences make the universal pronouncement that "Maithili journalism is only literary" an oversimplification.

The author's critical language is severe in relation to some journals. Remarks against Antika or allegations of editorial factionalism are certainly matters for historical debate; but, where the account lacks quoted reports, published replies, or the views of opposing editors, they should be read as the author's assessments. The book also bears witness to the literary disputes of its era. That does not reduce its significance; it increases the need for criticism of sources.

18. Maithili Journalism in Nepal: A Cross-Border Linguistic Public Sphere

Under "Maithili Periodicals in Nepal", the author connects the independent tradition of Nepal's Maithili-language journals with the context of Indian Mithila. He discusses the trilingual nature of Navajagaran and publications including Phulpat, Ijot, Maithili, Gamghar, Dubhi-Dhan, Hilkor, Naimikanan, and Salhes Vani. Literary exchange, cultural relations, and the difficulties of irregular publication are emphasized. (Printed pp. 54–55.)

The section's real contribution is its conception of a Maithili world of print extending beyond national borders. A change of country does not end the readerly connections of a language community. But independent documents would be needed to reconcile the dates of Nepal's Bikram Sambat calendar

with the Indian Gregorian calendar and establish local publishing policies, participation by Nepali, Hindi, and Maithili, and institutional histories. These brief notes should not be treated as a completed history of all journalism in Nepal. The author himself keeps the section short.

An external Nepalese review identifies Navajagaran as an early trilingual journal, but sources do not agree on its first publication year. Checking the editor responsible for its Maithili section, the date of the first issue, and the place of publication against an original copy would strengthen the cross-border section of this book.

19. Handwritten Periodicals: An Alternative Print World of Educated Rural Society

The book mentions handwritten journals such as Hitaishi, Ayachi, Govind, Akshat, Kiran, Lochan, Mithila Manas, Mitravani, Prabhat, Mandar, Janaki, Kaushiki, and Saurabh. It also discusses Maithili Sudhakar, Mithilodaya, Bharati, and Vaidehi in Kashi. In places the circulation of handwritten material through cyclostyled or copied versions is described. (Printed pp. 55–56.)

This is an exceptionally valuable section because it does not confine "publication" to commercial printing presses. Village students, local literary gatherings, and enthusiasts practised public writing through manuscript journals. Though their readership could be small, the tradition developed authors, language skills, and methods of collective editing. The author's concern over disappearing documents indicates the need for surveys of museums, private manuscripts, libraries, and student collections.

The limitation is that the book does not provide a surviving copy, writer's identification, file number, or present repository for every journal. The list is therefore a guide to searching, not a complete archival inventory. Without recognizing the difference, titles will survive in readers' memories while the material exemplars remain inaccessible to researchers.

20. The "Present" of 2006: Reading the Author's Historical Vantage Point Correctly

The "present" in the heading "Present-Day Maithili Periodicals" relates to the author's situation in 2006. It would be a historical mistake to treat this as their publishing status in 2026. The section mentions Ai-Kalhi/Samay-Sal, Bhangima, Bharati Mandan/Mandan Niket, Rachana, Mithilanchal Sampark, Maithili Akademi Patrika, Karnamrit, Mithila Mahan, Shrimithila, Bhumija/Mithimalini, Arambh, Ghar-Bahar, Maithili Sandesh, Hilkor, Jakhan-Takhan, Halchal, Mithila Darpan, and Vidyapati Times. (Printed pp. 56–62.)

The list reveals an intriguing diversity: Bhangima's specialization in theatre, Shrimithila's focus on economics, the administrative-literary Maithili Akademi Patrika, the migrant publication Karnamrit, the book-oriented and

literary Rachana, the news commentary of Ai-Kalhi/Samay-Sal, and community periodicals in different cities. The author praises editorial regularity and thematic breadth, while criticizing irregular issues, personal promotion, and factionalism.

The book's statement that "not a single Maithili daily newspaper exists today" is an assessment of circumstances in 2005–06. It does not support a direct conclusion about the media landscape in 2026. No speculative list of supposedly current publications has been added in this review.

21. The Contribution of Periodicals to Literary Development: The Book's Strongest Argument

Yoganand Jha credits the public forum of periodicals with the growth of modern Maithili poetry, fiction, drama, novels, criticism, memoirs, research, translation, and children's literature. The book supports this proposition with specific examples: Mithilamod's publication of books; Maithili Sahitya Patra's presentation of extended works; Batuk's children's literature; Abhivyanjana's new poetry; Maithili Kavita's specialization; Kathadisha's fiction; Bhangima's writing on drama; and Shrimithila's economic concerns. (Printed pp. 24–25, 28–29, 32–35, 42–43, 57–59, 63.)

A periodical creates an ongoing conversation: a work is published, readers respond, an editor raises a dispute, and subsequent issues carry replies and new writing. The book names numerous people and events in such exchanges. A history of modern Maithili literature based only on book lists would miss editorial selection, the contemporary form of literary movements, and the formation of readerships. The history of periodicals is therefore not an appendix to literary history but one of its fundamental fields of evidence.

Measuring that contribution would nevertheless require separate collection of publication periods, literary genres, generations of writers, debates, actual reprints, and awards. Yoganand Jha writes a qualitative history of influence; he does not provide systematic content analysis or an issue-by-issue index. This is not a failing so much as an identifiable methodological boundary of the work.

22. Language, Script, Standardization, and the Hindi–Maithili Relationship

The book links the early mixing of Hindi and Maithili, the rise of entirely Maithili journals, the improvement of orthography, preservation of the Tirhuta script, and the struggle to recognize Maithili as a distinct language. In the author's account, journals became key instruments of the language movement. The journey from Kashi's mixed-language periodicals to wholly Maithili publications in Darbhanga and onward to public daily newspapers was also the printed making of linguistic identity. (Printed pp. 24–27, 63–64.)

A second perspective is necessary. Language standardization is a social process involving editorial practices, readers' dialects, schooling, printing technology, and institutional decisions. The book summarizes this process but

offers no year-by-year comparisons of particular spelling variants or printing specimens. A linear conclusion that “standardization was completed by a particular journal” should therefore be avoided.

Some sections of the book cite partisan opinions from language activism concerning Angika and Bajjika. In studying this aspect of literary history, the book's editorial and political stance needs to be identified as the author's source-based position, not as a final linguistic classification. The literary, social, and educational histories of the individual language communities require independent study.

23. Maithili Journalism and Constitutional Recognition

In his preface, the author describes Surendra Jha “Suman”'s struggle, public meetings, efforts to establish a Maithili daily, petitions to Bihar's political leadership, and the raising of language demands in Parliament. In the conclusion, Maithili's inclusion in the Constitution's Eighth Schedule is connected with a notable achievement of the movement in the press. (Printed pp. 9–10, 63–64.)

This historical assertion can be compared with independent legal evidence. An official release of the Government of India's Ministry of Home Affairs dated 22 December 2004 states that Bodo, Dogri, Maithili, and Santali were added to the Eighth Schedule by the Constitution (Ninety-Second Amendment) Act, 2003, published in the Gazette on 8 January 2004. “Constitutional recognition” is therefore an independently verifiable event. However, proving a single-cause claim that recognition resulted solely from periodicals would require comparative investigation of parliamentary debates, organizational petitions, public agitation, and other political processes. Journalism was an influential participant, not an established sole cause.

24. Critical Standards: Regularity, Quality, and Social Influence Are Distinct

The book repeatedly employs such judgements as “short-lived”, “irregular”, “literary journalism”, “yellow journalism”, “factionalism”, and “self-satisfaction”. They reveal the author's historical concern with regular publication, financial honesty, factually reliable news, and accountability to the public. If a journal takes annual subscription payments but fails to supply its promised issues, criticism is justified. (Printed pp. 43–44, 62–64.)

But a serious charge such as “yellow journalism” calls for quotations from published material, responses to accusations, assessments of factual reliability, policies for issuing corrections, evidence of editorial self-interest, and demonstrable harm. Sharp language, allegiance to the political left or right, rejection of older literature, or experimentation with new metres does not automatically prove “yellow” practice. Several evaluations in the book appear without extensive supporting evidence. A historical review should not conflate an author's judgement with fact.

Likewise, short duration is not by itself a sufficient measure of failure. If a single special issue marks the authentic beginning of a new literary movement, its influence may exceed that of a durable but lifeless monthly. The book would become still more useful if economic sustainability, number of issues, editorial quality, readers' trust, breadth of subjects, social representation, and intellectual influence were treated as independent criteria.

25. The Missing History of Class, Caste, Village, Women, and Ordinary Readers

The author acknowledges that journalism did not adequately reach poor, unschooled, migrating, and everyday struggling populations in villages. This self-criticism is a serious achievement of the book. Yet the claim is accompanied by relatively little separate discussion of caste strata, economic class, women readers, Dalit communities, agricultural labourers, markets, or children as readers. The names of women writers, references to village journals, and works on social justice appear in places, but there is no systematic survey. (Printed pp. 18–19, 24–25, 32–33, 55–56, 64.)

A broader social history of Maithili journalism would ask: who paid the printing costs of each issue? What were subscribers' occupations, genders, language practices, and geographical distribution? Were journals sold in bookshops or circulated by subscription? Which women made editorial decisions and which merely submitted works? Members of which communities could get their everyday crises into print? Without answers, it is difficult to measure the reach of genuinely popular journalism.

This criticism is not a judgement imposed on the book by today's ideological preferences; it develops the book's own standard of public life. The author himself speaks of "class factors" and distance from ordinary people. A new method of gathering social evidence is needed to investigate his diagnosis.

26. Economic History: The Author's Diagnosis and the Limits of the Evidence

In the closing discussion the author attributes the brevity of many publications to insufficient business planning, irregular distribution, personal editorial preferences, fluctuating subscriptions, and lack of resources. Reminiscences of Swadesh's losses in the 1950s, Mithila Mihir Daily's institutional structure, and the number of issues of many journals provide differing examples. (Printed pp. 9, 20–23, 64.)

The research does not provide systematic tables of press expenditure, paper prices, distributors' commissions, postal charges, numbers of advertisers, per-issue sales, outstanding subscriptions, or editors' remuneration. Without these, the economic argument may be well directed but lacks quantitative corroboration. Account books, subscription registers, printing invoices, and editorial correspondence could supply new evidence for an institutional history of Maithili journalism.

Another question arises: must a regularly published journal also be in the public interest? No. Regularity may be one necessary condition of reliability, but accuracy of news, variety of opinion, and public accountability are separate values. The book's aspiration for a "sustainable daily" needs to be situated within this broader set of standards.

27. Criticism of Sources: How Strong Is the Evidence for Each Claim?

At the first level, publication details, a book's dedication, the author's own preface, page numbers, and titles can be checked directly against the source copy. At a third level are the author's interpretations of literary influence, social impact, the contribution to language activism, editorial tendencies, and causes of economic failure. Treating all these levels as equally "verified facts" would be a methodological error.

A rare strength of the book is its mention of the page layout, poems, columns, and editorial details of certain actual issues, suggesting first-hand examination. On the other hand, not every journal in the compiled list is accompanied by original issue dates, the editorial board, holdings information, and a location of surviving copies. Thus the book is an interpretive survey of a century and a guide for research, not a complete critical bibliography of periodicals.

Different dates such as 1905, 1906, 1908, 1909, and 1912 should not simply be dismissed as printing errors. The first issue, registration, beginning of a regular publication schedule, a new editor's appointment, relaunch, and relocation may each mark different moments. Until the earliest relevant issues have been examined, it is more honest to present later historians' opinions comparatively.

28. Dates That Could Be Checked and Questions That Remain Open

Maithil Hit Sadhan: the original book gives 1905; a research abstract about Jaipur published in 2021 and other histories also support the year. The first issue was not available for this study. Mithilamod: the source gives 1905, while external accounts offer both 1905 and 1906. Mithila Mihir: the source gives 1909, while external lists include 1908 and 1909, with 1912 elsewhere. Swadesh: the source dates the start of the daily to 9 October 1955, while a later online list says "1965". Mithila Mihir Daily: the source gives February 20, 1984, to June 1986; Dr Dhanakar Thakur's list also records a phase in 1984–1986. This study does not pronounce a final resolution of these differences.

Eighth Schedule: a Government of India source independently confirms the law—the Constitution (Ninety-Second Amendment) Act, 2003, Gazette publication of 8 January 2004. History of Maithili Journalism: Pandit Chandranath Mishra "Amar"'s book of 1981 was published by Maithili Akademi; this appears in a Bihar government book list and international library records. Yoganand Jha's mention of the earlier historical work is thus supported at the bibliographic level. (Original, printed p. 19.)

29. Wider Assessment: The Book's Distinctive Qualities

This book successfully attempts to examine a century of Maithili journalism as a whole. Its first distinguishing feature is its incorporation of migrant centres—Jaipur, Kashi, Ajmer, Agra, Kolkata, Delhi, Mumbai, Prayag, and other cities—within the print history of Mithila itself. The second is its treatment of different forms of publication—dailies, weeklies, fortnightlies, monthlies, quarterlies, research journals, children's magazines, little magazines, institutional souvenirs, and handwritten journals—within a single history of journalism. Its third is the distinction it makes between literary development and public communication when arriving at the author's conclusions.

A fourth distinction is the author's living recollections. His association with Suman, references to issues he examined, and participation in the language movement lend the book a personal historical colouring. A fifth is the book's candid self-criticism: the author acknowledges that his list may not be complete and sees how journalism has fallen short in social life. These admissions do not diminish the book's credibility; they clarify its purpose.

The book nevertheless has a major stylistic difficulty: its principal essay on the history of Maithili journalism is written in Hindi. This choice may have been intended to reach a broader immediate readership, but the author does not explain it. A review written in Maithili cannot conceal the fact. Further limitations are uneven source annotations and issue-specific evidence, a lack of quotations supporting harsh personal judgements, missing socio-economic statistics, and the brief treatment of Nepal, women editors, and handwritten periodicals.

30. Final Conclusion: From Literary Journals to Publicly Accountable Media

Yoganand Jha does not make a century of Maithili journalism into an unbroken celebration of success. Even as he praises its achievements, he asks why such a large mother-tongue community could not establish a sustainable system for public information and opinion. The book is consequently both history and a provocative editorial intervention. This perspective matters more than merely memorizing publication dates.

A reading of the whole book makes clear that Maithili journalism is not simply the history of a few unsuccessful dailies but a broad culture of print: the combined experiences of migrant communities, language movements, literary generations, school readers, theatre, women's editorship, scholarship, political argument, Nepal–India cultural contacts, and manuscript journals. Some projects appear short-lived by narrow commercial standards; measured against cultural memory and literary influence, their very issues may be invaluable.

The best use of this book is not to regard it as the final authority, but to begin new archival research from its extensive list of names, period divisions, editorial indications, and intellectual questions. Copies of original issues,

postal registers, advertisements, readers' letters, editorial replies, printing invoices, and records of women readers and rural distribution would deepen its history of a century. The book's essential contribution is that the author sees journals not only as places where literature is printed but as forums in which Maithil society creates its self-understanding, disagreements, and public future. In that sense One Hundred Years of Maithili Journalism is a useful and rich document of Maithili historiography, while also inviting criticism.

31. A Subject-Based Page Guide to the Original Text

Publication details, dedication, and messages of goodwill; intimate Maithili preface “Bhavya O Divya Prabha”, reflections on the centenary, Suman, Swadesh, and acknowledgements: printed pp. 1–16. Historical beginnings, Maithil Hit Sadhan, and criteria for journalism: pp. 17–19. “Daily Newspapers” (Swadesh, Mithila Mihir Daily): pp. 19–23. Early monthlies, migrant publications, and literary institutions: pp. 23–32. Experiments of 1950–1980, children's periodicals, research, politics, and little magazines: pp. 32–44. Periodicals of 1980–2005: pp. 44–54. Journals in Nepal: pp. 54–55. Handwritten journals: pp. 55–56. “Contemporary”, meaning periodicals of 2005–06: pp. 56–62. Historical conclusion: pp. 62–64.

CHAPTER 06 / 2007

Gahbar Songs

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

The basis of this critique is organized on three levels: (a) the book's preliminary particulars, dedication, and introduction; (b) the visible passages of songs, titles, repetitions, imagery, and narrative voice; and (c) explicitly identified external studies concerning wider classifications of Maithili folk song or debates over the folk, caste, and gender. The distinction between what the original book states and what the critic interprets has been maintained throughout.

2. The Significance of the Dedication: Bachchan Bhagat and the Contribution of a Living Tradition

The dedication page offers the most concrete preliminary evidence of Dr Yoganand Jha's field-oriented understanding of folklore. The book is dedicated to the memory of the late Bachchan Bhagat (1928–1991). According to the dedication, he lived in Bahadurpur, Laheriasarai, Darbhanga, practised the bhagati tradition, and possessed specialist knowledge of Gahbar songs. He was active among the people through numerous gohari performances or forms of ritual singing. The collector acknowledges his contribution to assembling songs for his doctoral research. (Dedication page; 1.)

This dedication is not merely a personal tribute: it also testifies to collaborative knowledge-making within an oral tradition. The printed volume circulates under the collector's name, but the memory, performance, and availability of its songs depend upon the bearers of the community's traditions. Precisely for this reason, the explicit identification of Bachchan Bhagat, his lifetime, and his documented contribution is a significant virtue of the collection. At the same time, these details do not justify concluding that he was the original composer of each song. The source presents him as a bearer of knowledge and a collaborator in the collection.

The language of the dedication relates Gahbar songs to the lives and cultural experience of people described as 'illiterate' or 'semi-educated'. A contemporary reader must approach these designations cautiously: exclusion from formal education does not imply an absence of cultural expertise. Bachchan Bhagat's role gives concrete form to this distinction.

3. The Idea of Gahbar: Singing, Ritual, and Invocation

The introduction treats Gahbar songs as a form of Maithili folk song associated with local beliefs concerning gohari and bhagatai. It describes the invocation of deities or ancestors, the belief that a divine presence or bhav comes upon a bhagat's body, bodily movement and trembling, calls uttered aloud, and the sequence of ritual actions. The collector understands this process and the songs as elements of a single, integrated tradition. (Printed p. 2.)

In this context, reducing the word 'gahbar' to a synonym for dense forest or poetic mystery would not accord with the evidence internal to the book. Within its semantic range, the term is a point of convergence among folk deities, the bhagat, the place of invocation, ritual objects, collective memory, and devotional practices. The accessible portion does not supply a definitive history of the spatial arrangement, architecture, or geographical distribution of Gahbar sites; no additional account of these matters has therefore been constructed.

The religious performance described in the introduction is a combined act of body and voice. Movements of the hands and feet, falling upon the ground, vocal expression, and the presence of ritual materials distinguish the song from a merely written lyric. The printed version supplies lines of verse, while an actual folk performance would also involve sequence, rhythm, melody, pauses, calls, and responses. This is a possibility suggested by the text, not a demonstrated analysis of sound. Musical transcription, metrical timing, and tunes are not available in the reproduced portions under examination.

4. The Introduction and the Editorial Perspective: Restoring Marginalized Voices

The collector observes that conventional collections of folklore have accorded particular prominence to certain songs belonging to 'elite cultural conventions', while many other folk songs have remained outside that

boundary. He presents his own collection as an effort to direct attention towards neglected Gahbar songs. (Printed pp. 1–2.) This proposition provides the book's cultural argument: the representation of folklore does not correspond automatically to social prestige, and the importance of a song cannot be determined solely through institutional recognition.

The introduction mentions the experience of bhav, the invocation of deities for relief from illness or during crises, incense, guggul resin, the dhak drum, sirni, cloth, and other articles of worship. In this collection, folk belief and everyday life are not separate domains. Illness, emergency, the agricultural world, collective offerings, and the memory of divinities all enter into the construction of a song's meaning. The book does not permit any scientific conclusion concerning the actual therapeutic efficacy of religious practices.

The introduction indicates a conscious preference for giving neglected Gahbar voices a place distinct from the conventionally recognized repertoire of songs. The collection's declared centre is the folk music of socially marginalized communities. This priority, however, does not by itself establish that every song belongs exclusively to a particular community or originated within a specific caste.

5. Kali, Salhes, and the Interwoven World of Divine Invocation

At the beginning of printed page 4, a song addressed to Kali employs language of severe bodily experience, images of weapons, offerings, and submission to a powerful goddess. The name of Salhes occurs alongside Kali's. The remembrance of Kali's popular divine power and the folk heroism of King Salhes within the same song-world suggests a relationship between religious narrative traditions. This is nevertheless a textual connection; it cannot establish the date on which two sectarian traditions originated or were historically fused.

'King Salhes descended from Mother's lap' — printed p. 4.

In this line, the tenderness of 'Mother's' body and the heroic image of the 'king' do not stand in opposition. Salhes's dignity emerges through a maternal relationship. This conjunction of motherhood, bravery, and divine protection is important in ritual poetry. On page 4, an utterance such as 'Teach me a little of your knowledge, too' appears as a plea for knowledge. The appeal creates a dramatic contrast between the worshipper's humble voice and the goddess's power.

On printed page 6, recollections of the goddess accompany images of colour, hair, teeth, clothing, adornments, and articles of worship. In the verse opening with 'Tisiya in the field of tisiya', a familiar agricultural object enters the rhythm of divine invocation. Ritual evokes not only a supernatural scene but also preserves the vocabulary of farming and the things necessary for life. The ordinary world and the goddess's world are bound together in the same thread of sound. (Printed p. 6.)

'Tisiya in the tisiya field, mustard in the lentil field' — printed p. 6.

On printed page 8, a questioning opening such as 'On what day, O Kali, were you born?' pursues details of the goddess's birthplace and birthday, flowers, forests, and fragrant substances. The goddess's supernatural authority becomes the subject of the familial curiosity characteristic of folk narrative. This song brings Bhagavati within the questioning and answering of popular life. The form 'When was the goddess born?' calls for a scene of birth, not a philosophical exposition of the absolute.

'On what day, O Kali, were you born?' — printed p. 8.

5.1 Songs of the Goddess, Songs of Kali, Mahamaya, and Phulmati

In the goddess song on printed page 5, references to bamboo, a small branch or staff (dagwa), and flowers accompany lines concerning the worship of the goddess. A verbal sequence such as 'With those flowers I shall worship Kali, my deity' evokes the ritual presentation of offerings. Lower down the same page, part of a heading beginning with 'Kali's...' is visible. Its complete title and the following lines cannot be read because of the limitations of the reproduced passage. This discussion is therefore not an imagined completion of the contents list but an examination of the scattered evidence concerning flowers, worship, and Kali that is actually available. (Visible portion of printed p. 5; 4.)

On printed page 9, 'Mahamaya' and 'Phulmati' appear in forms resembling headings. The opening lines 'Mahamaya came from the north' and 'Phulmati came from the middle' envision arrivals indicated by direction. The references to north and centre allow the entrance of deities to be experienced in sequence. This visual element accords with the drama of invocation; nevertheless, because the remaining lines are unavailable, neither the full itinerary nor a narrative about the relationship between the deities has been invented here. (Visible portion of printed p. 9; 6.)

The proximity of flowers, directions, invocations, and divine names in the goddess songs attracts attention. Their combined imagery gives poetic form to a ritual sequence of invocation. Yet the proximity of these divine names does not justify deciding that all the verses are portions of a single composition.

6. The Song of Lukeshari: Journey, Water, and the Deity's Arrival

The heading 'The Song of Lukeshari' is clearly visible on printed page 10. The verses contain a departing journey, Kashidham, the Ganga, Sonma, and several other geographical images, together with repeated calls to 'Lukeshari'. Lines such as 'the well's water' and 'clear water flows at Sela' connect water with local understandings of purity and the deity's world of travel. One particular feature is that the divine figure emerges through narrative movement: at one point the song summons, at another sends the figure onward, and elsewhere brings the figure to a riverbank.

'The water in the well, Baba, has gone foul and smells' — printed p. 10.

The line suggests the possibility of observation grounded in remembered experience: the water in a well can be pure or contaminated. Another line offers the contrasting image of clear water. Water in the song is therefore not

merely a religious symbol but also conveys qualitative differences in experience. To claim, however, that the whole song is a social movement against water pollution would exceed the evidence of the available text.

An imperative address such as 'Sela, Sela, do not bark, Goddess Lukeshari' brings out the dialogic form of invocation. Addressing a deity need not consist solely of praise: entreaty, restraint, or a command-like expression are also possible. This takes folk devotion beyond the requirement of uniformly submissive speech. (Printed p. 10.)

7. The Song of Bamati: The Conjoined Images of Forest, Separation, and Appeal

Under the heading 'The Song of Bamati', printed page 10 clearly contains a verse beginning 'The Brahmin lost himself on beholding Bamati's beauty'. One forest, a second forest, a great forest, and the image of a woman's scarf or anchal emerge successively. An appeal such as 'Release, release my scarf, O Brahmin' places the anxiety of a human relationship and the demand for release in a single situation. (Printed p. 10.)

'Release, release my scarf, O Brahmin' — printed p. 10.

To establish what 'Brahmin' signifies in this song—a social identity, a deity's guise, or a narrative character—one would need the full continuation of the song. The right-hand portion of page 11 has been cut off. Accordingly, no definite conclusion either of 'anti-Brahminism' or of 'support for Brahmins' is offered here. Yet the situation of a scarf being seized, and the plea that it be released, certainly opens questions concerning an unequal balance of power within a relationship. At such points the gendered implications of folk song require particular care.

8. The Song of Aghori: Body, Material Objects, and Intimate Names for the Divine

Under 'The Song of Aghori' on printed page 12, a sentence such as 'For want of what, O Nataji, has your face grown pale?' produces an image of deprivation, everyday care, and bodily condition. Betel leaf, ganja, flowers, and garlands appear among the song's details. These words are not simply ornaments of expression: they also form a possible inventory of ritual substances, though neither their method of use nor the region in which they were used can be established from this evidence.

'For want of what, O Nataji, has your face grown pale?' — printed p. 12.

An affectionate form of address such as 'Nataji' brings a domestic idiom into the relationship between the deity and the devotee. A distinctive poetic quality of folk religion is that social forms of address diminish religious distance. The song's repeated question asks why the deity's face has grown pale and anticipates an answer. Its conversational verse differs from the formal panegyric structure of a written devotional hymn.

9. The Song of Mahishasura: A Folk Voice Distinct from the Established Narrative

The heading 'The Song of Mahishasura' appears on printed page 12. The verses refer to 'Mahishasura' and use expressions such as 'where have you forgotten?' and 'servant'. The song's distinctive character inheres in the relationship between its heading and its mode of address: a name occupying a particular place in the classical narrative of the goddess enters here into the environment of folk invocation. Whether the Mahishasura of the classical narrative and the figure named in this verse are the same character in every respect, or whether he has assumed a distinct form within folk tradition, cannot be decided from the available extract.

'Where have you forgotten, O Mahishasura, the buffalo's nose-ring?' — printed p. 12.

Words such as 'buffalo', 'nose-ring', 'gona', and 'gotha' bring the imagery close to animal husbandry, bodily ornament, village spaces, and calls of address. To regard the song as no more than an echo of the Puranas would overlook this rural semantic world. Its creativity may be found in the duality between a familiar name from the Sanskrit-Puranic tradition on one side and the language of animals, household, and courtyard on the other.

10. The Song of Garib Bhuiyan: The Language of Poverty, Service, and Refuge

The heading 'The Song of Garib Bhuiyan' is clearly printed on page 12. The verse begins by asking 'Why does the bhagat go to Kashi?' and later includes a line such as 'Why was he sleeping with his wife beside him?' Pilgrimage, relationship, dwelling, obstacles, and service converge in the song. The word 'Bhuiyan' might designate a community or be an element in a character's name. A single printed heading, however, cannot establish the singer's caste, the historical background, or the history of an entire caste tradition.

'Why, O bhagat, do you go to Kashi; why to Prayag?' — printed p. 12.

The question-and-answer form gives the devotee's individual journey a social dimension. The religious geography of Kashi and Prayag, the intimate address of the home, and the conditions of the road together make devotion more than pilgrimage to an external sacred place: it becomes an experience lived through home, road, night, and wakefulness. The right-hand side of page 13 is missing, and the beginning of page 14 may continue the preceding song. The form of the song is presented here with that limitation explicitly in view.

At the beginning of printed page 14, lines concerning 'Dinanath' and the riverbank appear. They cannot immediately be identified as the definite concluding part of 'The Song of Garib Bhuiyan', because the intervening portion of page 13 is absent. Nevertheless, the recurring words concerning humility, river, body, and refuge within this adjacent sequence deserve examination.

11. The Song of Pir Baba: Folk Devotion Beyond Fixed Boundaries

The heading 'The Song of Pir Baba' appears on printed page 14. The lines beginning 'Aho Saheb Auliya Pir' address the pir through prayer, parts of the body, objects resembling offerings, fruits, and images of rivers or paths. Forms of address such as pir, saheb, and auliya prevent the world of Gahbar songs from being restricted to a single circle of divine names. The presence of devotion to the pir alongside Kali, Salhes, Mahishasura, and Karikh in this book is itself an established textual fact.

'O master, saintly pir; O master, saintly pir' — printed p. 14.

To declare this coexistence a modern ideological manifesto of 'equal respect for all religions' would impose an external ideal upon the text. The firmer conclusion is that the address to the pir forms part of the traditional language of worship and invocation within the local world of folk deities, where other divine names are also present. The song's oral structure is living evidence of religious encounter, but no numerical identification of the communities participating in the ritual is available.

Images of a 'seven-panelled kurta' and 'a ripe, prepared betel quid' turn material objects into affectionate gifts from the worshipper. The pir appears to enter popular dialogue rather than remain an aloof figure of conventional religious instruction. The continual repetition of 'aho' creates a vocal rhythm; through it, the verbal or bol aspect of the song becomes clearly perceptible.

12. The Song of Karikh: Forest, Water, Animals, and a Servant's Labour

The heading 'The Song of Karikh' appears on printed page 14, and the visible portion extends to page 16. It opens with a verse resembling 'The Amunija are cool, master, the Jamunija are cool'. On page 16, a cluster of terms such as 'along the riverbanks', 'hunting', 'manjar', 'piyar', 'forest', 'jamuni', and 'bakas' clearly conveys the song's natural setting and working-life imagery. The sequence of locations matters here: riverbank, interior forest, and a servant's actions combine to give the song's character movement.

'Along the riverbanks I went hunting, O beloved Karikh' — printed p. 16.

In one passage on page 16, the refrain 'Ram kedaliya vaname na' returns repeatedly. Without the complete text on page 15, the full religious significance of 'Ram' in this instance is difficult to determine. What is certain is that the recurrence of sound functions as an internal link between narrative verses. The repeated utterance of the same cue may assist memory and rhythm in collective singing.

'Your servant wandered through the difficult forest in search, O…' — printed p. 16.

The servant's first-person position exposes the social structure of address to a folk deity. The deity possesses complete power, while the servant strives without rest: the printed verse makes this relationship palpable. Searching in a

forest, obstacles on the path, hints of weather, and the desire to make an offering all connect faith with labour. Here the 'voice of working people' becomes not simply a theme but a poetic point of view.

Journeying, the forest, water, and the servant's narrative movement predominate in Karikh's song. Rather than remaining within the static praise of a deity, the verses bring out the folk hero's actions and relationship with nature.

13. The Language of the Text: Vernacular Speech, Verse Construction, and Grammatical Forms

Colloquial forms such as 'kaune' (which), 'kathi' (what), 'toharo' (yours too), 'hamaro' (mine too), 'sutalai' (slept), 'maiya' (mother), 'gharalau', 'bhel' (became), 'kahama' (where), 'kahu' (say), 'ancharwa' (scarf), 'nathwa' (nose-ring), and 'dularua' (beloved) are present in the songs. Replacing these forms with uniform literary equivalents could damage pronunciation, the sense of social and communal intimacy, and rhythmic inflection. Language here fulfils the purposes of vernacular performance independently of classical standardization.

The principal basis of the verse appears to depend not on a fixed syllable count but on the song's spoken utterance, refrain, question and answer, and repetition. Words such as 'kaune', 'kiye', 'aho', and 'he' open lines in many places. The parallel construction creates expectation in an audience: another form of the first question, a variation on the first name, or the return of the refrain. Its value for oral recollection is apparent; without recorded evidence of singers' actual exchanges, neither tempo nor melodic mode has been determined.

The printing also displays numerous regional and phonetic forms of Devanagari, variant word endings, and possible typographical errors. Editing demands a distinction between a 'mistake' and 'regional pronunciation'. Standardizing a repeated form of address, for example, may destroy the dialogue within a song. For a future critical edition of such a collection, the better procedure would be to present the original text as printed on one side and supply a separate glossary and list of variant readings on the other.

14. Imagery and the Beauty of Folk Poetry

An important aesthetic quality of Gahbar songs is their easy conjunction of exalted religious names and everyday objects. Kali appears alongside tisiya and mustard, Mahishasura with buffaloes and nose-rings, Lukeshari with a well and river, Pir Baba with a betel quid, and Karikh with riverbanks and forests. In these examples, folk belief is nourished by material life. The images in the verses unfold in the visual language of the village; the gods do not stand outside the village but move within its idiom.

Some verses fashion the goddess's body through extraordinarily intense and fearsome images, whereas elsewhere forms of address such as 'mother', 'lap', 'baba', 'beloved', and 'saheb' convey affection. These contrasting registers

disclose the emotional resources of folk religion: fear and trust, surrender and courage, the everyday and the marvellous do not merely compete but complement one another.

Every line contains an invitation to performance: the prolonged call 'aho', the closing 'he', the recurring question 'kiye', the refrain-like fragment 'na'. Even in written sequence, this verbal musicality can be felt. Yet without audible evidence it is impossible to identify a particular raga, quantitative metre, or form of dance.

15. Caste, Gender, and Religious Plurality: Evidence and Caution

The book's English introduction makes particular mention of the singing traditions of marginalized groups. Its dedication honours Bachchan Bhagat's knowledge of the tradition; its introduction expresses dissatisfaction with elite-centred methods of collecting songs; and its texts bring together Bhuiyan, bhagat, servant, pir, and numerous local divine names. When these three levels are viewed together, the book becomes an effort to preserve folk memory against social exclusion.

Even so, the name of a caste and the identity of an original performer are not synonymous. The heading 'The Song of Garib Bhuiyan' supplies textual evidence of the word 'Bhuiyan'; it cannot by itself determine the village, subgroup, year, singer, or original history of transmission of the song. The credibility of socially committed criticism depends on such caution.

From the perspective of gender, words such as Kali, goddess, 'mother', scarf, lap, and wife draw attention to female figures. The centrality of a female deity and the actual participation of women singers are two separate questions. The collection does not make available a list of male and female singers, a division of performances by gender, or a count by location. It would therefore be unwarranted to conclude that women directed the entire tradition. Yet the dramatic episode of the seized scarf in Bamati's song and Kali's figure of power offer possibilities for an examination of women's bodies and agency.

Religious diversity makes it impossible to confine Mithila's folk belief within a single rigid doctrine. The inclusion of a song to Pir Baba is particularly meaningful: its presence in the same book as Shakta songs is textual evidence of the plural structure of folk devotion. A history of literature must maintain the distinction between 'coexistence within songs' and 'universal harmony throughout society'.

17. The Collection's Achievements and Outstanding Questions of Textual Editing

The principal achievements of the book may be identified in three respects. First, songs of invocation that had remained at the margins of folklore were made subjects of written study. Second, the songs reveal parallel worlds of deities, folk heroes, pirs, forests, pilgrimage sites, household objects, labour, and affection. Third, the collector acknowledges Bachchan Bhagat's contribution on the dedication page, providing a valuable example that

departs from the common failure to name the people from whom folklore is received.

The limitations must be criticized in relation to specific textual evidence. The available materials do not systematically display each song's singer, village of origin, collection date, circumstances of performance, tune, performance sequence, local variants, and linguistic commentary. This does not imply that such particulars are necessarily absent from every unseen portion of the original volume; it means only that their presence cannot be confirmed from the material available. Such documentation is extremely important for a scholarly edition of folklore.

A reliable future critical edition should include high-quality facsimiles of every page, accurate printing of each song as originally recorded, marks of textual uncertainty where necessary, a glossary of dialect words, details of locations and performers, recordings when possible, and a distinct editorial appendix. The purpose is not to 'purify' and erase the original vernacular but to preserve its oral variety together with documentary evidence.

18. Conclusion: The Literary and Cultural Meaning of Gahbar Songs

The available text of Gahbar Songs shows clearly that the meaning of Mithila's folk poetry is not confined to the familiar traditions of festival or wedding songs. The bhagat's invocations, appeals to the goddess's power, remembrance of Salhes, Lukeshari's watery journey, the episode of the scarf in Bamati, the everyday setting of Aghori, Mahishasura's rural vocabulary, Garib Bhuiyan's sorrow, affectionate addresses to Pir Baba, and Karikh's story of forest, river, and labour together constitute a many-voiced cultural text. Here the religious world is formed not through concepts imposed from above but through vernacular forms of address, refrains, and communal memory.

The foundation of the historical significance of Dr Yoganand Jha's collection lies in its declared purpose and in the voices of the available songs. Between these two stands Bachchan Bhagat's contribution as recorded on the dedication page, representing a living tradition of popular knowledge. Criticism must acknowledge the book's achievements while accepting the present limits of the evidence. Where a text survives, there must be close reading; where a text is cut off, restraint; where another study is used for comparison, explicit identification of the source. Only through such discipline can reliable scholarship on Gahbar Songs be established.

Subject / Printed Text	Condition of the Text
Dedication page: Bachchan Bhagat (1928–1991), regional folk knowledge, and the collector's acknowledgement	Dedication clear; only part of the adjoining cover visible
Publication details: 2007, Mithila Research Society; portion of introductory p. 1	Publication details clear; p. 1 cropped
Introduction p. 2: Gahbar, bhagat, invocation, worship; portion of p. 3	P. 2 clear; p. 3 cropped

Subject / Printed Text	Condition of the Text
Printed p. 4: Kali–Salhes; fragment of a goddess song on p. 5	P. 4 clear; p. 5 cropped
Printed p. 6: verses to Kali; portion of p. 7	P. 6 clear; p. 7 cropped
Printed p. 8: Kali's birth and invocation with flowers; fragment of a folk-goddess song on p. 9	P. 8 clear; p. 9 cropped
Printed p. 10: songs of Lukeshari and Bamati; portion of p. 11	P. 10 clear; p. 11 cropped
Printed p. 12: songs of Aghori, Mahishasura, and Garib Bhuiyan; portion of p. 13	P. 12 clear; p. 13 cropped
Printed p. 14: fragment of preceding song, songs of Pir Baba and Karikh; portion of p. 15	P. 14 clear; p. 15 cropped
Printed p. 16: visible ending of Karikh's song, with an end mark	P. 16 clear; fragment of an advertisement alongside

CHAPTER 07 / 2007 • Second Edition 2024

Folk Life, Literature, and the Wealth of Words

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

Ultimately, the real literary question raised by this essay is not 'Are all the stories about Vidyapati factually true?' but 'Why and how do ordinary people fashion the figure of Vidyapati?' This question turns criticism somewhat away from the worship of an individual towards the interrelationship of text, society, and memory. Future research drawing upon comparative readings of folk ballads, temple traditions, and recordings of oral performances could increase the significance of this chapter.

2. National Integration in Maithili Folk Songs | Original pp. 30–35

The central proposition of this essay is that the local voice of Maithili folk song is not antagonistic to Indian cultural unity; rather, it is one of that unity's living expressions. At the outset, the author discusses cultural connections between east and west, north and south, standards of familial conduct, and shared spiritual symbols. He subsequently treats the folk song as a vehicle of collective ways of understanding life. At this point, folk song ceases to be mere amusement and becomes a medium of social memory, ethical values, relationships, and multilingual cultural interchange. (pp. 30–31.)

Through lines from religious and social songs, the original essay attempts to demonstrate a spirit of integration. It considers images of Rama, Krishna, gods and goddesses, family traditions, guests, respect within the family, and shared human aspirations. Its concluding portion identifies the place of songs in the vernacular alongside the material necessities of life and social cooperation. The examples suggest that the author's use of 'national' is not

restricted to the political meaning of the state but extends to the moral and cultural connectedness of communities. (pp. 30–35.)

From a critical perspective, this essay's strength lies in its search for a unifying emotional thread. An important qualification is nonetheless required: wherever folk songs express unity, love, and affection, they may also give voice to difference, grief, opposition, gender inequality, or social tension. If only songs of integration are selected, painful experiences and dissenting voices may become invisible. The representativeness of the chosen songs, their areas of collection, and the occasions on which they were sung are therefore indispensable to impartial research.

The words and tunes of folk songs generate social meanings together. Their written lines convey meaning to readers, but without details of performers, occasions of singing, communal responses, and rhythm, the fullness of folk experience remains inaccessible. The possibilities for extending this critique lie in comparisons of the social uses of songs, the performance roles of women and men, particular life-cycle ceremonies, and regional diversity. Variations of a single song in different villages might reveal cultural integration and local specificity at once.

This chapter's value rests chiefly in establishing an interpretive proposition and setting Maithili folk song within a wider Indian context. If treated as an argument in cultural interpretation rather than as a rigorous ethnomusicological survey, both its achievements and its limitations become clear. Its democratic interpretation would be enriched by examining evidence of social inequality alongside the idea of integration.

3. Sama–Chakeba in Maithil Folk Culture | Original pp. 36–46

The essay on Sama–Chakeba situates a distinctive song-and-drama tradition of Maithil folk life within a wide cultural setting. At the beginning, the author shows how folktales, folk songs, folk theatre, folk dances, local beliefs, and social practices interact within Maithil culture. Accordingly, Sama–Chakeba signifies not simply a festival ritual but a joint performance involving story, acting, song, the making of objects, communal celebration, and the structuring of relationships. (pp. 36–38.)

Central to the essay are the affection between brother and sister, the moral conflict of folk narrative, and the role of collective singing. The author places the subject within a tradition of book-based research by discussing earlier scholars, collectors of folklore, and the contexts of the songs. The original includes commonly sung lines associated with Sama and references to Ramdev Jha and Rabindranath Tagore, making clear his use of comparative cultural indications. He points towards understanding story and folk song not as identical literary genres but as interdependent modes of presentation. (pp. 39–43.)

What distinguishes the essay is its attention to performance. In Sama–Chakeba, figures, symbols, games, songs, and collective actions become different media of the same emotional experience. To designate it 'living folk

theatre' in a critical study, one would require evidence of practice: who performs each role, what sequence the songs follow, whether the daily procedure changes, and what relationship obtains between audience and performer. Such questions do not contradict the essay's proposition; they can strengthen its explanatory power.

The ideal of affection between brother and sister may be an important meaning of this folk festival. Yet the aspects of communal gathering among women, memory, joking, and the right to speak deserve equally serious attention. The festival narrative helps establish social order, while its songs and performances may also create informal freedoms within that order. Examining this double meaning makes Sama–Chakeba intelligible not as a rite confined within the home but as a wider public cultural event.

The textual achievement is the author's recognition of a tradition specific to Mithila as a legitimate subject of folklore studies. Further research should document the inventory of sources, local versions, recordings of song and music, arrangement of figurines, and changes in the festival over time. Such work could take the present discussion beyond abstract praise towards a reliable history of performance.

4. The Folk Ballad of Dina–Bhadri | Original pp. 47–56

The essay on Dina–Bhadri is among the book's most important entries concerning social history. It begins by considering agricultural labourers' work, the absence of land ownership, caste arrangements, and the social circumstances of the Musahar community. To explain the setting of the ballad, the author describes communal livelihoods, traditional forms of labour, and local class distinctions. Its heroes are thereby situated not as purely supernatural warriors but as folk heroes emerging from a particular world of work and social tension. (pp. 47–49.)

The main narrative concerns Dina and Bhadri, their family and community relationships, and their confrontation with oppression. The author presents the struggle through the verses, passages of dialogue, narrative development, and incidents of the ballad. The text displays a conjunction of defiance, revenge, valour, collective loyalty, and popular religious belief. At one point, the author discusses the influence of Krishna's subjugation of Kaliya and indications associated with Tantra. The ballad thus provides an example of local historical experience existing alongside a wider mythological memory. (pp. 49–53.)

The essay's notable critical achievement is to place the Musahar community at the centre of scholarly attention. In the mainstream of Maithili literature, the lives of socially marginalized people have often received something like the place of a footnote. Here their struggle possesses the independent dignity of its own oral epic. Nevertheless, each social character in a folk ballad need not be taken as a directly attested historical person. The narrative time of the ballad, the time of its collection, and the possible age of the social memories it

carries may differ. Preserving these distinctions does not diminish its social significance; it makes its historical use more dependable.

The succession of ballad verses is rich evidence of a community's collective experience. Its textual form need not always have remained the same; different artists may alter the rhythm, dialogue, character attributes, and episodes. Recording performers' identities, the places and circumstances of collection, sources, and variant readings is therefore an essential next stage of research grounded in the folk. In studying caste, it is especially important to see the community not merely as passive victims but as makers of their own ethics, beliefs, resistance, and creativity.

The essay's critical usefulness lies in the questions it poses concerning labour, power, and dignity through a local heroic ballad. If the narrative presented by the author is read on three separate levels—as sociological hypothesis, mythological structure, and the craft of oral literature—it opens many possibilities for comparative work on Hindi and Maithili folk ballads.

5. Gahbar Songs | Original pp. 57–70

The essay entitled 'Gahbar Songs' concentrates on the classification of folk songs, their cultural uses, and the textual preservation of a little-discussed tradition. At the beginning, the author names numerous forms from Mithila's extensive repertoire of folk song: sohar, samdaun, wedding songs, seasonal singing, songs associated with particular castes and occupations, and songs attached to religious narratives. Against this broad background, his decision to give Gahbar songs a distinct introduction is important, for it reveals how many specific social and ritual forms are concealed within the general category 'folk song'. (pp. 57–58.)

The original chapter contains a substantial body of song texts. Verses concerning Kalika, Gor, Sonora, and Mahamaya, together with patterns of recurring lines, suggest the internal rhythm of such songs. On page 63, there are successive repetitions in a Kalika song and a separate mention of 'Mahamaya's Song'. The significance of this material is not merely that new songs are quoted: geographical names, symbols associated with the goddess, images of travel, and the voice of communal singing become visible in relation to one another.

An important cultural accomplishment of this work is bringing an otherwise little-recorded body of songs into the relatively stable archive of a printed book. When oral song passes from a singer's voice to the reader, gains and losses occur together: words are preserved, but inflections, pauses, melodic turns, responses, and the living circumstances of the performance do not survive easily. Accordingly, recordings, the singer's name and community, principles of transcription, and evidence concerning song order would multiply the evidential value of such research.

Understanding the religious and cultural significance of Gahbar songs requires examining the relationships among goddess worship, particular places, and communal gatherings. Caution is necessary, however: the

occurrence of similar words for deities does not demonstrate identical origins or uniform practice throughout an entire region. Versions may develop in relation to social position, caste practice, and occasion. Preserving local differences as valuable is more productive than searching for one supposedly 'authentic' form.

As the last essay in the folklore section, 'Gahbar Songs' casts a new light on the preceding four essays. After myth, integration, festival, and heroic ballad, the folk voice here reaches the reader in its own words. The chapter is therefore significant both as a collection and as an interpretation. A fuller edition with critical textual editing and musical analysis of the selected songs would be a natural direction for future research.

PART TWO: LITERATURE

6. The Use of Figures of Speech in the Dramatic Songs of the Poet Jivan Jha | Original pp. 71–77

The opening chapter of the literary section examines Jivan Jha's dramatic songs through the principles of classical poetics and the theory of figures of speech. It begins by referring to the poetic thought of Acharya Vishvanatha. The author treats figures of speech not as the fundamental condition for poetry's existence but as a powerful means of enhancing poetic beauty. This raises a question: does a figure of speech remain confined to verbal ingenuity, or does it become part of a character's feelings, dramatic situation, and the effect of a song? The author aims to examine the formal craft of dramatic songs by this criterion. (pp. 71–72.)

The chapter refers to simile, poetic fancy (utpreksha), metaphor, and several semantic figures of speech. On page 74, the author examines examples of figures of meaning to discuss the combined effects of verbal arrangement and sense. Where nature, beauty, emotional expression, and a character's speech operate together in Jivan Jha's dramatic songs, the value of a figure lies not simply in its classification but in its contribution to dramatic meaning. The author's method of presenting examples seeks to offer an initial answer to this question.

The distinctive feature of this essay is the use of classical terminology to examine local creative writing. Vishvanatha's concepts, the qualities of poetry, and the theory of rasa should not be imposed as self-evident truths. In dramatic song, metre, characterization, stage time, and the pace of dialogue are separate elements. A clear explanation of the boundary between a figure of speech and an ordinary poetic image is important to the essay's critical reliability.

Jivan Jha's dramatic songs stand between folk music and written literature. Their analysis ought therefore to consider the effects of sound, pronunciation, group singing, and acting. If a line offers a simile on the page but creates a dramatic space for humour, compassion, or irony in performance, the range of its poetic meaning expands. Combining formal classification with the study

of theatrical practice would consequently be a valuable undertaking for subsequent research.

Taken as a whole, the essay demonstrates that Maithili dramatic songs are worthy of analysis through Sanskrit poetics. The next criterion of evaluation should be how representative the chosen examples are of Jivan Jha's dramatic works as a whole, and which figures recur because of particular theatrical needs. Analysis attentive to frequency and context would make the book's preliminary argument more concrete.

7. Women's Education and Harimohan Jha | Original pp. 78–85

This essay relates the question of women's education in Mithila to Harimohan Jha's social satire and narrative writing. It begins by referring to traditional female figures associated with the pursuit of knowledge and to historical examples, before turning to modern educational inequalities, social control, and the need to educate women. This groundwork makes it possible to read Harimohan Jha's work not simply as humour and satire but in the context of social reform. (pp. 78–79.)

The essay considers social satire in works such as Kanyadan and Dvadasho'dhyaya, along with contrasts between educated and uneducated lives. The discussion of Kanyadan on page 81 raises the relationship among English education, the marriage system, the bridegroom's conduct, and women's experience. The importance of the argument lies in making education more than the act of attending school: it becomes a question of self-determination, social consciousness, and changing family relationships. (pp. 80–82.)

Harimohan Jha's writing exposes social hypocrisy through satire. In criticism, however, the narrative voice, a character's speech, and the writer's own convictions must not be treated as identical. The absurdity of a character's actions may prompt social reflection in a reader; establishing the author's ultimate judgement requires consideration of the entire narrative structure. Firmly maintaining this methodological distinction would make the analysis of his social purpose more precise.

Nor is it sufficient, when discussing women's education, to divide 'tradition' and 'modernity' into two simple compartments. Customs, marriage, economic security, the mother tongue, colonial education, and social prestige exist in complex relationships. Harimohan Jha's stories express such tensions through satire. Further study could separately examine the linguistic autonomy of female characters, their power of decision, the targets of ridicule, and the actual consequences of education.

The essay's principal achievement is to identify women's education as an important social concern within Harimohan Jha's literary world. A question concerning its limitations is how fully it compares the differing voices of social change. Comparison with contemporary Maithili writers, including women authors, would lend greater depth to the debate within literary history.

8. Pandit Anand Jha's Maheshshatak | Original pp. 86–89

This short, four-page essay introduces the Shaiva devotion, verses, and poetic language of Pandit Anand Jha's Maheshshatak. It opens with quotations from hymns to Shiva and establishes connections with the tradition of Shaiva lyrics associated with Vidyapati and Chandra Jha. In the author's view, addresses to Shiva as Vishvanath, Visheshvarnath, Hara, and Shankara do more than express worship: they suggest religious sensibilities translated and recreated in the Maithili language. (p. 86.)

Alongside devotional verses, the chapter mentions secular rites, marriage, domestic quarrels and separation, folk practices, and cultural signs. It thus becomes clear that religious verse and literary representations of social life are not mutually exclusive possibilities. To appreciate the beauty of Maheshshatak, it is necessary to move beyond praising a deity's greatness and attend to the local character of the diction, the rhythm of address, Shaiva thought, and the incorporation of folk experience.

Brevity is both the advantage and the limitation of this essay. In a small space, the writer introduces the subject and presents its principal features. But a systematic study of the poetic form of a shataka would require examination of the numerical implication of 'hundred' in the title, the full list of the work's verses, its variant readings, and the state of available edited editions. Without these, it is difficult to decide whether the beauty apparent in individual examples characterizes the work as a whole.

Although devotion to Shiva is a traditional religious subject, its expression in Maithili has distinctive linguistic features. A close consideration of modes of address, local rituals, the words of songs, and the mixture of Sanskrit poetic vocabulary could develop this essay into research on literary style. In particular, evidence of transformations between literary Maithili and the Maithili of oral ritual would illuminate the social character of devotional literature.

Overall, the essay on Maheshshatak is a suggestive introductory criticism. It directs readers towards the work's religious and literary importance, but it cannot be regarded as equivalent to the rigorous evidence of textual editing. Within the collection's diversity, this brief chapter secures an essential place for Shaiva devotional poetry.

9. Shakta Elements in Radhaviraha | Original pp. 90–101

In this substantial essay, the author examines the relationship between the Shakta tradition and the poetry of Radha and Krishna's separation. The introduction discusses goddess-motherhood, compassion, the woman as a manifestation of power, creation, and the varied forms of worship within Indian Shakta sensibility. Against this background, in reading Radhaviraha by Pandit Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup', he searches for possible convergences of Krishna's divine play, Radha's love, and the principle of the goddess within a single poem. (pp. 90–92.)

The original essay offers quotations relating to the opening benediction, embodiments of divine power, and the appearances of Radha and Krishna, then interprets them. On page 95, the author argues in particular that Krishna, as the poem's hero, can on one level be understood as the centre of Vaishnava love and divine play, while on another he can be connected to cosmic images of power and creation. The real subject of this argument is not the addition of one sectarian label to another but the reinterpretation of symbols and principles within the poem. (pp. 93–96.)

The essay's critical strength is its intertextual reading. Shakta, Vaishnava, Puranic, and rasa-related symbols arise from different traditions. The analysis is fruitful when it remains anchored in the text and examines the circumstances in which these traditions intersect in the poet's work. Yet a general reference to a goddess or praise of feminine power does not, in itself, justify a definite sectarian conclusion concerning Shakta philosophy. Establishing a Shakta element requires evidence of distinctive philosophical marks of Shakti, the relevant poetic context, and the element's narrative function.

'Separation' is generally explained as an emotionally intense experience of the absence of union. But within criticism of this poem, the possibility also exists of understanding separation as a spiritual search, life's incompleteness, a longing for renewed connection, and a symbol of cosmic unity. In this reading, Radha becomes not merely a heroine in separation but an active centre of meaning. The critical question is how far Radha's independent agency survives an interpretation based on Shakta principles, and whether she is sometimes reduced to a philosophical sign of power.

The significance of religious and intellectual synthesis is the essay's principal contribution. Further concrete research would benefit from the complete sequence of verses in Radhaviraha, the arrangement of narrative episodes, possible Sanskrit, Bengali, and Maithili intertexts, and comparative inventories of Shakta terminology and Vaishnava poetic traditions. These resources could clarify the balance between the critic's intuitive reading and evidence present within the work itself.

10. Harikrishnalal Das, Singer of the Rama Narrative | Original pp. 102–107

The chapter on Harikrishnalal Das identifies a distinctive link in the tradition of Maithili Rama poetry and sectarian devotional expression. Its opening discusses Vidyapati's linguistic and literary influence, the antiquity of Rama narratives, and Mithila's tradition of singing stories about Rama. By mentioning several medieval poets of Rama narratives, the author seeks to situate Harikrishnalal Das within an evolving tradition rather than treat him as an isolated poet. (pp. 102–103.)

The essay's central question is how the classical tradition of Rama poetry relates to the songs of everyday Mithila. In songs for life-cycle ceremonies—sohar, badhaiya, samdaun, and other occasional forms—the story of Rama and Sita becomes entwined with the feelings of local families. The author's

presentation shows how the religious character of written poetry acquires a living form in the village's singing traditions. The social use of poetry is as important as the words it contains.

In verses presented near page 107, a sense of pride in Maithili becomes particularly apparent. The author represents Harikrishnalal Das's contribution not simply as a repetition of Rama devotion but as an awareness of the cultural importance of language. In literary evaluation, these aspects require separate attention: poetic craft, language, and narrative by one set of criteria; popular circulation, cultural influence, and the transmission of devotion by another. Their combination would allow a fairer assessment of the poet's contribution.

The chapter compares poets while tracing their place within a traditional sequence. But presenting that literary genealogy as rigorous history would require dates for each poet, editions of the original texts, and evidence of creative similarities. Shared narrative elements from the Rama story do not automatically establish direct literary influence. Separate examination of linguistic borrowing, verse construction, narrative differences, and contemporary contexts would produce a more trustworthy history of this succession.

In brief, the essay draws attention to the sung and sectarian currents of Maithili Rama poetry. Its introduction to a particular writer helps point towards a neglected space in Maithili literary history. A fully documented account, however, would require comparative editing of collected verses, printed editions, and oral performances.

11. Children's Literature by Dr Shailendra Mohan Jha | Original pp. 108–113

The chapter on children's literature begins with questions about literature suited to particular ages. The writer connects children's intellectual development and their ready powers of comprehension with literature's educational and creative roles. On page 108, he sets out the contexts of the oral traditions of Maithili children's literature, inspiration from Sanskrit narrative literature, and the development of literary writing. Seen from this perspective, the discussion of Shailendra Mohan Jha is not merely an introduction to one author; it is an attempt to recognize a separate cultural place for the Maithili child reader.

The original essay mentions the range of genres in Shailendra Mohan Jha's writing and identifies specific works. Page 108 names works including Pratibha and Madhushravani and indicates his activity in novels, essays, stories, and poetry. The author's critical concern is that the writer's wider literary formation cannot be separated from the aesthetic shaping of writing for children. Suitability for children does not mean simplicity of subject alone; it also involves the depth of the imagination, fluency of language, and presentation appropriate to age.

In studying writing for children, 'instructive' and 'literary' qualities should not be considered synonymous. A story may teach good conduct but remain limited as literature if it lacks independent characters, humour, curiosity, and

artistic experience. For that reason, analysis of individual works should examine narrative pace, conversational dialogue, elements of fantasy, uses of the impossible, and the active participation of the child reader.

The linguistic question is also important in Maithili children's literature. There is often a distance between the language of the home, the school curriculum, and printed literary language. How an author's works bridge language acquisition can be investigated through the actual responses of reading groups. Rural and urban children, first-generation learners and habitual readers, and children of different ages may have different experiences. Recognition of such possible variety is an important requirement of contemporary criticism of children's literature.

The essay's contribution is its treatment of Maithili children's literature as a field worthy of serious literary discussion. Bringing together sufficient examples from distinct works, publication years, intended age groups, illustrations, and evidence of reader reception would allow future research to identify the distinctive features of Shailendra Mohan Jha's writing more securely.

12. The Consciousness of an Age in Yatri's Literature | Original pp. 114–121

The essay 'The Consciousness of an Age in Yatri's Literature' evaluates the Maithili writings of Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' and their social thought. Its opening mentions the novels Paro, Navturiya, and Balchanma, together with the poetry collections Chitra and Patrahin Nagna Gachh. Examining Yatri's work by the criteria of ideas, language, and craft, the author illuminates the writer's identification with the people and concern for society. (p. 114.)

The principal concept of the essay is yugabodh, the consciousness of one's age. The term means not simply listing contemporary events but recognizing sensitivity within a work to class relationships, experiences of exploitation, linguistic change, social awareness, and human struggle. The significance of the popular and socially rooted vocabulary of Yatri's literature lies in the way his poems and stories turn readers towards the concrete conditions of social structures. The essay makes an explicit demand that social questions be considered alongside, and apart from, traditional celebration of literary greatness.

The relationship between Yatri's Hindi and Maithili literary worlds is especially important for research. The character of an author's writing, readership, and organization of subjects may change with the language employed. The essay discusses the relationship between Yatri's fame and his contribution in Maithili, providing the basis for a wider comparative study. Yet identical ideas appearing in two languages do not necessarily imply identical style, narrative voice, or linguistic symbolism.

In discussing a progressive viewpoint, equal weight must be accorded to the density of lived experience and to artistic structure. Commitment to society may be an important literary virtue, but the internal contradictions of a narrative situation, the multidimensional nature of characters, the

suggestiveness of language, and the shaping of metre and sound remain separate critical questions. If political intention is taken to exhaust literary meaning, the complexity of a work is reduced. It is therefore fruitful to read yugabodh as an indispensable dialogue between thought and art.

The achievement of the essay is its identification of the people-oriented voice of Maithili modernity. Future researchers could test its argument through separate examples of character, linguistic register, narrative perspective, and reader response in selected novels and poems by Yatri. In this way, the essay becomes a dependable entry point into a wider interpretation of literary history.

13. Kiranji's Satya Sandesh | Original pp. 122–128

This essay considers the literary personality of Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran' and the importance of the periodical Satya Sandesh. At the outset, the author discusses Kiran's extensive activity in poetry, short fiction, children's stories, epic poetry, one-act plays, drama, novels, essays, criticism, and journalism. Satya Sandesh can accordingly be read not merely as a periodical title but as a platform for the public discussion of Maithili language and literature. (pp. 122–123.)

In examining the magazine, the author places particular emphasis on social questions, linguistic consciousness, and editorial vision. Page 125 discusses statements in Satya Sandesh relating to the advancement of Maithili and social responsibility, citing the ideas of Sir Ganganath Jha, Swami Vivekananda, Homi Modi, and Mahavir Prasad Dwivedi. Their inclusion reveals an attempt to connect a cultural and linguistic campaign with a wider Indian intellectual tradition.

The particular importance of this chapter lies in treating editorial prose as evidence for literary history. Editorials address their contemporary readership, shape opinion, and bring institutional questions into public view. Yet editorial voice, the period of publication, the editorial structure, readership, and actual social impact are independent research topics. Distinguishing between 'proposed in a journal' and 'implemented in society' makes the estimation of a periodical's importance more consistent with the evidence.

Concern for the mother tongue, linguistic dignity, and Mithila's educational and cultural life predominates in the original essay. In studying the history of a language movement, it is useful to construct separate chronologies for declarations of intention and actual institutional achievements. Issue-by-issue contents, interruptions in publication, news items, advertisements, correspondence, readers' reactions, and changes of editors would together make possible a full history of Satya Sandesh.

Overall, the author presents Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran' as both a creative writer and a public thinker concerned with language. This chapter offers an entry into the history of Maithili periodicals and modern linguistic identity. The next stage would require checking its arguments against paper or digital copies

of particular issues, allowing the writer's reputation to be weighed against the periodical's historical contribution.

14. Pratijnapandava: Poet and Poem | Original pp. 129–142

This essay on Pratijnapandava by Babuaji Jha 'Ajnat' is among the most extensive discussions in the collection's literary section. The author begins with the poet's biography, earlier writings, and the Sahitya Akademi Award. The original essay gives 1995 as the poem's publication year and 1904–1996 as the poet's lifespan; these particulars are reported here as statements in the original essay. The Sahitya Akademi's official list records the 2001 Maithili award under the names of this work and Babuaji Jha 'Ajnat'. (p. 129; Akademi list of awardees.)

The essay's principal concern is the relationship between poet and poem. Creating a modern Maithili epic from a narrative belonging to the Mahabharata brings together the language of the inherited story, contemporary moral questions, and an emotional recomposition of its characters. The author's analysis attempts to relate the poet's life experience, classical formation, lexical resources, and the ethical significance of the narrative of a vow. In this context it would be insufficient to treat the poem as merely a retelling of an ancient story.

A 'vow' can be interpreted not only as a hero's private pledge but also as public responsibility, a source of tensions in relationships, and a moral measure of social conduct. In testing these possibilities against the text, it is necessary to ask separately which incidents refer to the vow, what meaning the narrator assigns to characters' decisions, and what conclusion the poem reaches. Readers may take the author's appreciative evaluation not as a final self-evident judgement but as a critical invitation to return to the original epic.

The span of pages 129–142 indicates that, compared with shorter essays, the author has given more space to biography, literary sources, verses, and evaluation. Alongside appreciative language, the kind of evidence deserves attention. A poet's year of birth or the date of publication can be established from bibliographical records; poetic beauty through textual analysis; and social influence through histories of reading. If these distinct standards are mixed without differentiation, scholarly evaluation of the epic may become one-sided.

A systematic comparative list of narrative arrangement, division into cantos, metres, Sanskrit and Maithili diction, dialogue, roles of women characters, and differences from mythological sources would be especially useful to an epic's criticism. Such analysis would show where the work is original and where it follows tradition. The value of this essay lies in indicating directions for that research; reducing it to a chronicle of praise in place of full textual criticism would diminish its importance.

Taken as a whole, the essay brings literary biography and the examination of a work together. The independently verifiable 2001 award gives the poem a

clearly defined place in Maithili literary history, but an award is not itself the ultimate proof of aesthetic merit. Independent criticism of the poem's craft and the moral question of the vow remains an important direction for further research.

PART THREE: THE WEALTH OF WORDS

15. Vocabulary Related to Bamboo Work | Original pp. 145–160

The final section decisively broadens the thematic scope of the book. 'Vocabulary Related to Bamboo Work' begins with the Indian concept of shabda-brahman and the cultural importance of linguistic wealth. The writer maintains that collecting, explaining, and determining the meanings of words are essential procedures in language study, because countless words with specialized meanings arise in the everyday labour of society and may disappear as their uses change. In this view, occupational vocabulary comprises not merely names for objects but accumulated knowledge of methods, implements, craftsmanship, and social experience. (p. 145.)

The structure of the vocabulary is not simply an alphabetical list. The text explains meanings by naming types of bamboo, its constituent parts, methods of cutting and trimming, tools, partly finished materials, products such as baskets and storage vessels, and fine distinctions between stages of work. For this reason, several context-specific terms may be found for a single broadly defined object. Where a word has more than one form of pronunciation, the author records the alternatives. The value of this approach lies in making visible within a written linguistic collection the precise distinctions employed by a community of workers. (pp. 146–159.)

On page 152, a distinct subsection begins under the heading 'Vocabulary Relating to the Products of Bamboo Work'. It discusses household articles made from bamboo, storage constructions such as the bakhari, operations involving kuch or kuchi, differences of small-scale shapes, and specialized terms for manufacturing skills. This material is significant as a practical science of craftsmanship. A word's meaning is often determined not only by the object's form but also by its use, the stage of its manufacture, and the perspective of a skilled worker. Explanatory discussion is therefore more useful than the ordinary one-line synonym supplied by a general dictionary.

Up to page 159, the discussion continues through technical terms for local implements, bamboo strips, fastenings, joints, and finishing. As the material changes form, the word used for it changes too: the possibility of process-centred semantic classification emerges clearly. Comparing the successive terms for a first rough cut, a fine strip, differing phases of weaving, and the finished object, for example, would disclose a structure of artisans' working knowledge within the vocabulary. A standard dictionary cannot easily accommodate all such differences; hence the importance of a specialist explanatory lexicon.

Three distinctions are necessary in criticizing this section from the standpoint of lexical science: spoken form, difference of meaning, and material referent. Without regional interviews it cannot be established whether distinct names for an apparently identical object are geographical dialect variants, changes between generations, or indications of different stages of craftsmanship. Likewise, merely supplying a Hindi or Sanskrit synonym does not communicate the full phonetics, gender, number, case usage, and occupational meaning of a local word. The author's collection could become the basis of further linguistic research in these areas.

The vocabulary also has profound sociological importance. Recognizing bamboo-working communities as active producers of knowledge, and incorporating that knowledge into the central resources of the written language, requires reconsideration of the relationship between the centre and margins of literature. Words absent from the lexicons of high literature may be indispensable in this occupation. The social standing of words cannot be separated from the standing of those who use them; in that sense, an occupational vocabulary raises questions of linguistic dignity.

An expanded inquiry could become the basis of digital linguistic documentation if it recorded, for each word, a normalized Devanagari headword, local pronunciation, functional definition, village or district of use, picture of the object, sequence of operations, example sentence, grammatical characteristics, alternative names, variants, and the interviewer's date. An important ethical question also arises: when artisans' knowledge is collected, the communities concerned must be given recognition, credit, and access to the materials.

Within the collection as a whole, the vocabulary of bamboo work supplies a fundamental research insight: literary language is formed not only from words in books but also through the experience of labour. The society encountered in the folklore section through its songs and ballads appears in the final section through its manual skills and language of specialized meanings. Linking the two is among the book's most distinctive intellectual achievements. (pp. 145–160.)

Integrated Critical Discussion

1. From Folklore to Linguistics: The Logic of the Whole Collection

The book's three-part arrangement is not accidental from a critical point of view. The first part assigns meaning to the tales, songs, festivals, and ballads of folk life; the second examines written authors, books, and periodicals as forms of public literary expression. The third treats vocabulary particular to labour in folk life as a resource for linguistic knowledge. A clear relationship between culture, creation, and language thus emerges: society creates symbols; literature reorganizes them; vocabulary gives names to the fine distinctions of experience.

It is nonetheless insufficient to say that the book is unified merely by the breadth of its author's interests. The criteria for studying figures of speech differ from those for a social reading of a folk ballad or the documentation of technical vocabulary. The coexistence of these methods is the book's strength, but it also requires readers to change their sense of what counts as evidence from chapter to chapter. In one place a song's words constitute evidence, elsewhere the plot of a published text, and in another the name of a tool or product. Clarifying this diversity of evidence allows a fairer study of the book as a whole.

The triad of 'folk', 'literature', and 'the wealth of words' in the title constitutes, in condensed form, a social philosophy of language. Without the folk, a language community remains incomplete; without literature, artistic expansion of meaning is limited; and without the words of craft, life's technical experience remains invisible. The collection's distinctiveness thus lies not within a single mode of writing but in the prospect of dialogue between different modes.

2. The Distinction among Evidence, Sources, and Interpretation

A proper assessment of the ideas in essays of different kinds requires keeping 'source' and 'interpretation' apart. The Ugana narrative of Vidyapati is a source of folk memory; it is not a direct archive proving a historical event. The song of Dina–Bhadri is literary evidence of social experience associated with the Musahar community, but the historical date of each episode requires independent examination. The Sama–Chakeba performance is a social practice wider than a written folk-theatre text. Assessing the worth of Pratijnapandava requires examining the epic's actual artistic organization.

The author's criticism shows clearly both emotional engagement and respect for the text. These qualities bring neglected works and traditions into view. But research-based criticism must state the basis of appreciative claims, criteria of selection, and possibilities of alternative interpretation in every instance. Admiration for a poem or the cultural dignity of a folk ballad does not replace critical examination. On the contrary, strong criticism offers evidence of more serious respect for the work.

Many essays reflect the writer's interests at a particular moment, the circumstances in which materials were collected, and the sources then available. Today's wider accessibility of bibliographies, manuscripts, sound archives, and digital sources offers new ways of answering old questions. Yet it would be wrong to dismiss older studies simply because modern research tools were not available to them. A fairer procedure is to assess their contemporary achievements and the need for updated research by different standards.

3. Caste, Labour, and Language: Recognition of Neglected Knowledge

Reading Dina–Bhadri together with the vocabulary of bamboo work reveals an important possibility within this book. The first discusses a heroic ballad and collective memory belonging to a community of workers; the second brings forth precise linguistic classifications of occupational

knowledge. Both demonstrate that the record of history is not preserved solely in courts or the utterances of great poets. It also lies in ordinary labourers' narratives and songs and in the language of their tools.

A lexicon of labour may also document social hierarchy. What does the community manufacturing a particular article call its fine subdivisions of work? Which names have been imposed from outside, and which terms are disappearing over time? These questions concern linguistic and social history simultaneously. Future research will be more ethical and dependable if working communities are treated not as passive sources of 'folk material' but as knowledgeable agents with rights over their knowledge.

4. Women's Voices, Cultural Ritual, and Social Criticism

Bringing together the separate studies of Sama–Chakeba, Gahbar songs, women's education, and Radhaviraha reveals a multilayered picture of women's positions. Women's cultural participation in a folk festival, their collective voices in songs, aspirations to education in modern fiction, and Radha's power of love in devotional poetry place 'woman' in four distinct contexts, not as a single unvarying figure. Language of experience, social constraints, and the possibilities of expression change from genre to genre.

The subject must not be confined to goddess worship or celebration of the ideal woman. The exalted status of a goddess may coexist with restricted educational opportunities for living women; freedom to sing in a folk song is not identical to authority over family decisions. Examining these contradictions could become an important line of research inspired by the book. Interconnections between its separate essays thus enable the reader to discern the distance between society's ideals and its practices.

5. The Language and Style of Maithili Criticism

The author's Maithili prose combines classical definitions, common folk expressions, and literary analysis. In essays on folklore, descriptive use of terms such as 'ballad', 'song', and 'integration' is distinct from the analytical use of 'figure of speech', 'rasa', 'consciousness of the age', and 'devotion' in essays on literary subjects. The final vocabulary extends this linguistic horizon to tools, shapes, and names of products. The book's language thus changes form according to its subject; this stylistic variety is a genuine characteristic of the essay collection.

In many places a Sanskrit-derived stream of philosophical terminology occurs alongside naturally flowing Maithili narrative sentences. The advantage is conceptual precision, though it may also increase the burden of interpretation on readers. Notes, brief glosses of difficult words, and references could extend the accessibility of a published edition. In the name of making meaning clearer, however, it would be inappropriate to change folk expressions or the original pronunciation of quoted songs. Scholarly accessibility and the authenticity of dialect are equally important.

Methodological Achievements and Research Questions

Achievement 1 — Breadth of subject. The volume makes folk genres, particular literary texts, the criticism of writers, language movements, and technical lexicography worthy of study within a single book. Its cultural range consequently extends far beyond an individual writer's biography.

Achievement 2 — Closeness to the text. References to songs in the essays on folk ballads and music connect the author's analysis to particular linguistic materials rather than leaving it as a merely abstract argument. Scholars may return to the original passages on this basis and test their own interpretations.

Achievement 3 — Linguistic preservation. The treatment of technical terms connected with bamboo work points towards documenting artisans' skills and the richness of semantic distinctions in Maithili. Respect for local knowledge gives the work a distinctive character.

Question 1 — Documentation of oral sources. When broad social conclusions are drawn from ballads and songs, research is strengthened by details of the place and date of collection, singer or narrator, occasion, and textual variants.

Question 2 — Verification of historical claims. Biographies, publication years, historical narratives, and awards require a documentary basis distinct from literary argument. Where possible, publisher's pages and official institutional lists should be consulted.

Question 3 — Balance between theory and the text. Categories such as figures of speech, Shakta elements, consciousness of an age, and national integration are defined in advance. Before turning them into conclusions, one should examine examples within the work that support and challenge them alike.

Question 4 — Representation of society. The different voices of gender, caste, work, community, and generation in folk life should not be dissolved into a single collective 'voice of Mithila'. Recognition of diversity within a shared tradition increases the subtlety of historical understanding.

Final Evaluation

Folk Life, Literature, and the Wealth of Words deserves serious reading for three particular contributions. First, it treats Maithili folk genres as legitimate subjects of literary criticism. Second, it connects the writings of modern and traditional authors with Mithila's wider cultural environment. Third, it insists that the specialist vocabulary of forms of labour such as bamboo work is a foundational resource of Maithili. All three contributions point in one direction: the history of language and literature cannot be written without the many-layered experiences of society.

From the standpoint of criticism, the value of the book lies not in accepting each proposition as an indisputable truth, but in the responsible initiation of numerous questions for research. Distinctions between myth and history, the

representation of folk song, the social memory of ballads, multiple dimensions of women's concerns, limits on the applicability of classical theory, balanced assessments of individual writers, and regional authenticity in technical vocabulary all offer ample scope for investigation. The book's achievements become clearest when it is neither reduced to an object of praise nor measured by one inflexible formula of evidentiary rigour.

The most useful approach for this book's readers is to recognize that literary excellence, the dignity of folk life, and the knowledge embodied in language enrich one another without being interchangeable. The collection offers a sound basis for multidisciplinary questions to scholars of Mithila's cultural history, the history of Maithili criticism, the documentation of folk drama and song, and the compilation of local technical dictionaries.

CHAPTER 08 / 2009

The Vocabulary of Traditional Caste-Associated Occupations in Maithili

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

1. Introduction to the Book and Its Structure

The title The Vocabulary of Traditional Caste-Associated Occupations in Maithili contains three interconnected subjects of study: the Maithili language, traditional productive life, and the specialized vocabulary associated with occupational communities. This is not simply a collection of synonyms but a study of the linguistic organization of materials, divisions of labour, craft methods, and local experience within a rural economy. Dr Yoganand Jha's book was first published in 2009 by the Mithila Research Society, Darbhanga.

The book includes 'Athato Shabda Jijnasa' ('Now, an Inquiry into Words', p. 5), a preface (p. 41), contents (p. 47), a list of abbreviations and signs (p. 50), introduction to the subject (p. 51), Chapters One (p. 55), Two (p. 65), Three (p. 133), Four (p. 195), Five (p. 243), Six (p. 301), and Seven (p. 363), followed by a conclusion (p. 394) and appendices (from p. 398). The list of works consulted begins on page 404. This sequence shows the expansion of the discussion from social background to material vocabulary and linguistic analysis.

2. Athato Shabda Jijnasa: The Purpose of Compiling a Lexicon (from p. 5)

The principal questions in the opening section concern the acquisition of words, regional knowledge, and preservation of linguistic materials. 'Inquiry into words' here does not mean spelling alone, but the search for a word's purpose, sense, circumstances of use, and the knowledge of everyday life it embodies. The author's insistence on a detailed occupational vocabulary is

significant because many living technical terms are preserved in social practice outside written literature.

The meaning of a word connected with an occupation is rarely exhausted by a definition in a general dictionary. The materials of woodwork, their constituent parts, stages of shaping, dimensions of tools, uses of finished products, and defects in workmanship, for example, form distinct lexical groups. The author's selection thus makes regional lexicography a shared foundation for linguistic and ethnographic studies. A future critical edition would, however, greatly benefit from explicit details of each word's geographical area, speaker, date of collection, and variant pronunciations.

3. Preface, List of Signs, and Introduction to the Subject (pp. 41–54)

The preface establishes the relationship between social practices and linguistic units. The principal issue in the introduction is that it is difficult to explain the vocabulary of an occupation adequately without understanding its historical character. The regional forms of Maithili, technical terms, and traditions of oral knowledge cannot be separated from one another.

The list of signs and abbreviations is an indispensable aid in using the lexicon: without explanations of abbreviated forms, phonetic representations, shifts of meaning, or contextual references, the reader may be unable to interpret many entries. From a research and editorial standpoint, uniform explanations of each sign, cross-references between related forms, and identification of primary evidence would increase the lexicon's reliability.

The Collection's Extent and Awareness of Its Limits

On page 54 of the original, the author himself acknowledges that a complete and comprehensive collection of Maithili occupational vocabulary could not be achieved in a single research undertaking. He explicitly recognizes the possibility that names for many occupational activities, implements, and products have been omitted. It would be inappropriate to dismiss this admission as a sign of weakness: it should be read as the natural awareness of limits characteristic of field-based lexical collection. Its concrete implication for researchers is nevertheless that the book represents an 'available collection', not a final and exhaustive list of occupational terms throughout Mithila.

Three questions are important in understanding the author's undertaking: what object or process existed in social practice; what artisans called it; and what its local or historical meaning was. The first six chapters display the lexical riches of objects and work, while the seventh places the material within a linguistic perspective through discussion of etymology, phonetics, semantic extension, and standardization.

On page 55, the author defines 'tradition' in relation to practices and beliefs transmitted between generations, and 'occupation' in relation to work, craft, livelihood, and skill. In these definitions, the meanings of words emerge from the social practice of production. Compressing the subject into the phrase

'caste occupation' would lose knowledge of tools, material selection, the uses of objects, and the competence of workers. The lexicon's importance lies in 'viewing names alongside living processes'.

Sources and Evidence for the Lexical Collection

The references on page 54 and the 'List of Works Consulted' beginning on page 404 demonstrate the importance of literary, linguistic, and folkloric sources. Literary quotations, words of vernacular speech, regional pronunciation, and the author's explanations represent distinct kinds of evidence. Finding a historical occurrence of a term in a published book is not the same as proving its currency in contemporary usage. The distinction is essential to reliable lexical interpretation.

4. Chapter One: The Social Background of Traditional Caste-Associated Occupations in Maithili (pp. 55–64)

This chapter lays the social and historical foundation of the lexicon. Its contents include 'Tradition', 'Occupation', 'Traditional Caste Occupations', 'Traditions of Caste-Associated Occupations in Mithila', evidence from cultivated literature and traditional folklore, classification of Mithila's occupations, and social life in relation to occupational castes. The fundamental point is that occupational names, the organization of work, and the language of work develop in a particular cultural environment.

Reading cultivated literature alongside folk literature is useful. Literary references reveal the symbolic image of a craft within society, while songs, sayings, and expressions in use are often closer to practical methods. A literary allusion should not, however, be taken automatically as an uncontested historical description of the actual production process. In analysing relations between social strata and inherited skills, economic change, intergenerational transmission of work, training, and social mobility are significant.

Four Perspectives on Traditional Occupations

The first perspective is historical. Evidence of a word's antiquity may be found in written literature, but literary mention is not the same as directly attested historical practice. The second perspective is anthropological: communal rules, communication, division of labour, and transmission of skills within an occupational group. The third is semantic: which words identify an object, a process, a condition, a virtue or defect, or a social role? The fourth is critical: to what extent do caste-based classifications accommodate the realities of work shared among communities and changes of occupation? These questions should be considered together in interpreting the contents of the book.

Tradition and Fixity Are Not the Same Thing

Knowledge of traditional work passes from one generation to another, yet words continue to change because tools, market demand, and the availability of materials change. In the concluding section the author discusses new scientific implements, occupational change, and the disappearance of words

(pp. 394–395). The opening chapter therefore establishes a background not of 'frozen tradition' but of tradition in motion. Read together, the background and conclusion make clear that the lexicon is not simply a collection of the past: it records a phase of change in which older and newer terms may coexist.

The Critical Limits of Caste Classification

Respect for the expertise of local artisans and support for caste-based discrimination are two different things. If the book's historical classifications are accepted unchanged as rules for contemporary social life, its research purpose would be distorted. An appropriate method preserves the author's categories as original evidence while also including in comparative surveys occupations not restricted to particular castes, tools shared across groups, women workers, and newly trained generations.

5. Chapter Two: The Vocabulary of Wood and Bamboo Occupations (pp. 65–132)

5.1 Woodworking

The contents list distinguishes many stages of woodworking: raw materials; parts of trees; defects, grain, and types of timber; metal articles; compounds and other materials; tools for roughening or cutting; planes; implements for scraping, shaving, and hollowing; measurement; trimming; hammering and extracting; agricultural and transport uses; house construction; articles for dining and rest; ornamental objects; protection of possessions; and other miscellaneous products. The original sequence clearly attempts to organize the vocabulary according to practical operations in a craft.

5.2 Bamboo Work

The chapter classifies bamboo work under 'raw materials—tools—products—conclusion'. Artisans' knowledge is transmitted between generations through terms associated with bamboo's flexibility, splitting, weaving, and joining. Whether shape-based and purpose-based names differ in the manufacture of baskets, vessels, everyday household objects, and agricultural implements is an important question for further research.

Woodwork: Material, Tools, Actions, and Products

Chapter Two, beginning on page 65, opens its discussion of woodworking with local practices and traditions of wood and bamboo in Mithila. Pages 78–79 discuss saws, boards and planks, planes, and distinct actions involved in cutting. The detail shows that the seemingly simple expression 'cutting wood' encompasses numerous technical stages: separating timber, levelling, measuring, joining, cutting grooves, forming edges, and smoothing the surface. The finely differentiated language of popular skills identifies these steps separately.

On page 79, in explaining types of planes and their construction, the author records words that a general dictionary would lose within one brief definition. In analysing variant terms for instruments such as the ara and ari saw, writing

'synonym' is not sufficient: which form is used for which size or operation is a separate question. The author's descriptions suggest that many names correspond to technical distinctions. Creating separate indexes for 'classes of objects' and 'classes of work' would consequently reduce confusion about meaning.

Words Expressing the Sequence of Operations: A Reading of pp. 78–79

Read as a workflow, the descriptions of saws, planes, planks, splitting, roughening, cutting, making grooves, and joining shutters show that the meanings of technical words depend largely on the relations between operations. A material that is presently raw timber may take on a different name after the first operation; after another tool has been applied, its name or descriptive qualities may change again. This semantic process is a grammar of vocational training, distinct from ordinary language instruction.

A critical dictionary would clarify the technical meaning of a tool's name by recording its shape, construction material, manner of holding, direction of movement, object worked upon, and result of its operation. The discussion of woodworking demonstrates the need for such multilayered description.

The Special Place of House-Construction Terminology

Pages 102–103 offer a detailed account of building materials made from wood and bamboo. Structural parts of houses, posts, beams, bamboo joints, roofing arrangements, practices of binding one part to another, and work involving frames or wooden members all belong to the material vocabulary of building. The author records several local forms for a single building element on these pages. To understand a term for part of a house, its orientation, load-bearing role, and place in the sequence of construction should be considered together.

House-building terms also raise questions concerning historical geography. The availability of timber, abundance of bamboo, conditions of flooding and water, and local architectural styles may form the background to lexical development. But where direct evidence for such a connection is lacking in a particular entry, it remains only a proposed explanation. Actual measurements and photographs of rural houses in Mithila would be valuable in verifying the terminology.

The strongest feature of woodworking vocabulary is its description of the qualities and defects of material and stages of use. From an artisan's standpoint, defects in timber are not merely a category of botany; knots, cracks after cutting, splitting, curvature, strength, and moisture can be decisive in choosing how it is used. Local craft practice must therefore remain central in determining the meanings of these distinctions.

Bamboo Work: A Different Logic of Weaving and Construction

The 'raw materials—tools—products—conclusion' arrangement for bamboo work (concluding on p. 132 in Chapter Two) stands alongside that of woodworking. Cutting and joining are common to both crafts, but splitting

bamboo into fine strips, bending it according to its flexibility, and forming the edges of woven articles require distinct technical knowledge. If a word for 'cutting' occurs in both trades, one cannot assume that its circumstances of use are identical.

On page 132, the author mentions forms influenced by Sanskrit, Persian, Arabic, and English in the vocabulary of wood and bamboo, and acknowledges the effect of regional variation in pronunciation. This observation raises the question of language contact within Maithili craft terminology. Establishing the etymology of a specific word, however, requires comparing older dictionaries, successive sound changes, and historical instances of usage.

6. Chapter Three: Vocabulary of Earth- and Water-Based Occupations (pp. 133–194)

6.1 Vocabulary Associated with the Potter Community

In the original contents, pottery-related terms are grouped under 'raw materials—supplementary materials—tools—tools and implements for preparing clay—firing equipment—uses—vessel terminology—worship—domestic use—occupational use—sacrifices, life-cycle rites, and festivals—other materials—terms expressing qualities and defects of vessels'. The classification reveals a linguistic journey from the manufacture of objects to their final use in social customs.

Successive technical terms develop in relation to types of clay and the operations of kneading, shaping, drying, firing, and colouring or decorating. A vessel's name denotes more than shape: its meaning changes with its social use, whether for storing food or water, worship, or life-cycle rites. The vocabulary is important evidence of Mithila's material culture. A specialist study would benefit from distinguishing terms for the raw, partly fired, and finished states of the same object.

6.2 Vocabulary Associated with the Mallah Community

The subsection on Mallah occupations comprises raw materials, tools, boat transport, technical terms, occupational activities, boats, nets, fishing rods and bamboo implements, other tools, products, varieties of fish, parts of fish, associated terms of sale, types of enemies or predators, the gathering of makhana and water chestnuts, and a conclusion. This extensive arrangement suggests local classifications of river- and pond-based livelihoods and aquatic resources.

Terms for boats, nets, and fish reveal fine technical distinctions within collective experience. Waterways, movement of water, fishing methods, the parts of fish, and distribution of products all involve words that represent not simply the social identity 'Mallah' but practical environmental knowledge. The inclusion of makhana and water chestnuts demonstrates the many-sided character of water-related livelihoods. This section could be read alongside environmental dictionaries and oral histories of work.

The States of Material in Pottery: From Clay to Vessel

At the beginning of Chapter Three (pp. 133–194), the author discusses the background of work based on earth and water in considerable detail. On page 133, forms such as mati, maati, and mitti bring linguistic variation into view together with the relevance of potters' work. 'Clay' here is not merely a natural substance but a manufacturing material that changes form. Its practical names and properties change across the stages of grinding, kneading, mixing, shaping, drying, and firing.

On pages 144–145, the author describes the arrangement known as an awan for firing vessels, relating terminology to fire, fuel, methods of stacking vessels, stages of firing, and the uses of earthenware. If awan refers specifically to a kind of firing chamber, reducing it to the ordinary words 'fire' or 'kiln' would sacrifice its distinctive meaning. From the artisan's perspective, the organized place where heat is applied is an important element of the technical definition.

The Relation between Material and Occasion in the Names of Vessels

The contents distinguish terms concerning vessels' use, dining, worship, rites of passage, festivals, miscellaneous articles, and their merits and defects. The scheme shows that a vessel of the same form may perform different functions when its social context changes. 'Storage vessel', 'cooking vessel', 'ritual vessel', and 'festival vessel' differ in more than physical shape. Names may include senses of utility, restriction, convention, and collective memory.

An important distinction suggested by the source is that an object's 'meaning' and its 'function' are not the same. For example, when a vessel for holding water is used in a religious ceremony, its context of use changes even though its established name may remain the same. Conversely, similar vessels made from identical material may acquire different names because of their shapes or uses. Semantic analysis should therefore keep four markers distinct: material, form, purpose, and occasion.

Place Names and Water Transport in Water-Based Occupations

On pages 162–163 of the Mallah section, the author gives numerous local terms for rivers, ponds, deep places, canals, and reservoirs. Aquatic vocabulary does more than identify landforms: it provides a practical map for transport, fishing, setting nets, and understanding depth. Many terms differ according to size, depth, availability of water, or geographical position. Collecting this semantic diversity could document local environmental knowledge.

Types of water bodies and the tools of Mallah workers occupy different semantic fields, but they are linked in practice. The shape of a boat or net may be affected by current, depth, or the character of a bank. Special evidence of occupational practice is nevertheless needed to establish precisely which tool was used for which type of water body.

Fish Names, Sizes, Conditions, and Sale

On pages 180–181, the author discusses names of fish, dried fish or sukati, the management of water, fishing conditions, the operation of nets, the distinction between fresh and spoiled fish, and vocabulary associated with selling. Here the passage from 'living fish' to 'food' also changes the relevant meanings. A form such as sukati needs to be understood in semantic study as a name connected with a processed state of the material.

Vernacular fish names should not be treated as exact equivalents of biological species names. One local name may encompass several biological species, or one species may be known by different names in different locations. Scientific identification should not be asserted without independent biological evidence. The original book supplies linguistic evidence, not a verified inventory of biological taxonomy.

Makhana and Water Chestnuts: The Wider World of Aquatic Livelihoods

The original contents place work connected with makhana and water chestnuts inside the vocabulary of Mallah occupations. This arrangement indicates that the author's idea of 'water-based work' is not confined to boats or fishing. Food production, gathering, processing, and sale also belong to an aquatic ecology. It would nonetheless be improper to conclude that every occupational connection with water products has remained historically fixed within one community.

In the conclusion of Chapter Three (p. 194), the author particularly discusses regional variation and lexical change in the vocabulary of Mallah workers as compared with potters. This is a valuable observation for criticism: the spread and use of terms for stationary earthen vessels may differ from terms associated with mobile activity on water. Statistical testing of the observation remains a task for future work; one cannot measure the scale of the difference from a conclusory sentence alone.

7. Chapter Four: Vocabulary of Fibre and Thread Occupations (pp. 195–242)

Chapter Four comprises raw materials and tools for fibre and thread work, bar or bad, spinning wheels, spindles, the charkha, properties of twisted thread, textile construction, equipment and processes, warp and weft, the looms of Patwa workers and Julahas, finished products, other related occupational vocabulary, and a conclusion. The sequence brings together the terminology of three technical stages: preparing thread, arranging the warp and weft, and making cloth.

The distinctive feature of this chapter is its vocabulary of movement and arrangement: turning, twisting, stretching, filling, weaving, forming edges, and identifying merits and defects. Many words in textile production denote operations rather than materials. Within the same manufacturing process, names for tools, their parts, workers' actions, and types of finished cloth form an interconnected semantic network. Mapping this network demands

attention to the grammatical relationships between action, instrument, and result.

The Beginning of Fibre and Thread Work: The Entire Textile Chain

On page 195, the author distinguishes the roles of Julaha weavers, Patwas, tailors, cotton carders, dyers, and washermen in fibre and thread occupations. Thus 'textile vocabulary' is not simply a technical lexicon of looms: it encompasses the stages from raw cotton or fibre through spinning, weaving, dyeing, stitching, and washing. 'Textile production' is not an isolated instant belonging to one particular worker but the outcome of a multistage social process.

The author begins with the raw material called bad and the method of preparing thread from it (p. 195). Its different conditions, fragility or size, and the twist of thread affect later results in weaving. The vocabulary of preparing thread therefore has an independent place between the names of raw materials and finished cloth. A lexicon should arrange 'fibre → thread → warp and weft → fabric → finishing' as mutually cross-referenced entries.

What Do Terms for the Parts of a Loom Tell Us Scientifically?

On pages 204–205, the author discusses the sequence of operations associated with tas, khas-khas, rachh, lardi, pachhan, and threads. These terms are unfamiliar to many outside readers because they designate not ordinary objects but particular loom parts or places and stages of work. Supplying synonyms without a diagram of the loom leaves their meanings only half explained. A new research edition should therefore accompany each original term with a labelled drawing, dimensions of the implement, and the moment at which it is used.

In linguistic terms, the words form a 'functional system'. Which part remains stationary, which revolves, which pulls the thread, which establishes the upper or lower position, and which winds up the completed fabric? Without such descriptions the technical names may be remembered while their meanings remain unclear. The author's extended explanations alleviate this difficulty to an extent.

The Language of Fabric Construction, Defects, and Correction

Pages 222–223 discuss stretching cloth to dry it, dyeing, attending to the edges, removing defects, and giving fabric its final form. The lexical collection appropriately accords importance to these finishing stages, since 'woven fabric' and 'fabric ready for use' are not the same condition of an object. Dyeing, starching, spreading, and finishing enter the vocabulary as named operations.

Families of terms derived from verbs deserve attention in this section. A root verb may be related to a name for the worker, an implement, the object resulting from an action, or an adjective expressing a quality or defect. Actual local usage is decisive in this kind of morphological analysis.

The chapter also offers an opportunity to study modern lexical change critically. Machine-spun thread and factory-produced fabric may have displaced loom-centred terms of the period. Such a possibility accords with the general changes discussed in the author's conclusion, but a list of which words have actually disappeared today would require a contemporary field survey.

8. Chapter Five: Vocabulary of Metal Occupations (pp. 243–300)

8.1 Blacksmiths

The blacksmith subsection ranges from raw materials and tools to equipment for heating, gripping, hammering, cutting, and piercing; supplementary instruments; products for general and specialized use; ornaments; and other miscellaneous objects. Technical processes involving temperature, force, form, and sharp edges are concentrated in metalwork. Failure to distinguish instruments from operations can therefore generate serious uncertainty about meanings.

8.2 Brass- and Copper-Vessel Workers

The section on kasera metalworkers is organized around raw materials, tools, implements for heating, hammering and cutting, supplementary tools, products, metal vessels, articles associated with food and drink, vessels for worship, and other words. The cultural dimension of this classification is important: metal vessels enter the domains of production, dining, and ritual. Collecting distinct names for the metal, shape, manufacturing method, and purpose of a vessel provides a basis for understanding Maithili's material vocabulary.

8.3 Goldsmiths

The goldsmith subsection includes raw materials; tools for heating, hammering, holding, cutting, and joining; other implements; products and ornaments; jewellery worn on the head, nose, ears, neck, arms, wrists, hands, and feet; terms associated with teeth; tools; and a conclusion. Beyond the naming of objects, this section makes possible a systematic examination of names derived from parts of the body and social occasions.

Processes of heating, hammering, cutting, and shaping occur in all three subsections—blacksmiths, kasera workers, and goldsmiths—yet the value of the materials, uses of products, and their social symbolism differ. A comparative vocabulary could investigate differences of sound and form for the same action among occupational communities and the extension of meaning in names for shared tools.

Principal Blacksmith's Tool Names: pp. 246–247

On pages 246–247, the author expands upon terms for blacksmiths' gripping and striking tools, solid metal plates used as bases, means of maintaining a fire, arrangements for supplying air, and operations involved in changing the shape of material. In these descriptions the names of tools also imply bodily actions: a gripping instrument protects the hand from burning, a

striking tool transmits force, and the base plate resists the blow. It is important to see distinct systems of operation within the single category of 'tools'.

In the history of craftsmanship, the technical meanings of words connected with heat must be understood. Not every instrument in the blacksmith's section on 'heating' is another name for fire: some generate heat, others supply air, some grip heated materials, and others alter their shape. Without these functional distinctions, a mere translation of the words into Hindi or English would remain incomplete.

The Social Range of a Blacksmith's Products

Agricultural implements, household fittings, metal tools for woodworking, kitchen equipment, and defensive articles are among the many categories of products connecting blacksmiths with other trades. The original list does not enable every available product name to be brought under a single definition, but its classified analysis clearly shows that blacksmithing terms relate to the fundamental system of tools in the wider rural economy. The manufacture of an object and its use by a customer occupy different semantic fields.

Kasera Workers: Vessel Shapes and the Condition of Metal

On pages 274–275, the book describes finishing components of kasera work, shapes of vessels, plates and round dishes, the making of rims, and work on metal surfaces. Names appear to relate to an object's shape, metal, use, depth, or construction of its edge. A name used by an artisan cannot be assumed to be identical to the name used by someone in the household. If they differ, both kinds should be recorded.

Separating vessels according to their place in cooking, dining, worship, and decoration offers opportunities for studying cultural semantics. A single vessel may be an ordinary article for serving food while acquiring a fixed function in a specific rite. Examination of this double meaning requires contextual examples of actual usage; a picture of an object alone should not be used to assert a universal social significance.

Goldsmiths: Purity of Metal, Shaping, and Ornamentation

On page 275, the author begins to discuss metals associated with gold, jewellery, alloys, and basic materials. Goldsmiths' vocabulary covers many practical conditions of one material: metal purity, melting, drawing wire, joining, chains, linking ornaments, and wearing them on the body. To treat goldsmithing terms as no more than 'a list of jewellery' would therefore narrow the scope of the source.

On pages 294–295, the book discusses the construction of chains, links, beads or units, ornaments worn on parts of the body, and special shapes in detail. Rings and links of similar appearance may bear different names when used for different technical purposes. The abundance of terms describing minute forms on the pages devoted to goldsmiths reveals the creation of a record of the local, fine-grained knowledge of handicraft.

A Semantic Map of Body Parts and Ornament Names

The contents arrange the products of goldsmiths according to their places on the head, nose, ears, neck, arms, wrists, hands, feet, clothes, and so forth. Semantically, this is 'location-based naming'. Jewellery may take its name from the material of which it is made or from the part of the body on which it is worn. These two relationships of meaning should be examined separately.

The symbolic meanings of ornaments linked to social occasions, marriage practices, or styles of dress in particular regions form a separate topic of study. The book's vocabulary provides an important foundation in that direction; however, the cultural meaning of each ornament must be tested against its contexts and actual usage.

Comparative Features of Three Metalworking Trades

Taking the common verbs of blacksmiths', kasera workers', and goldsmiths' operations as a basis for analysis is useful. Yet the object, force, temperature, and result of the verb 'to hammer' may differ across all three trades. An identical sound, therefore, need not designate the same action. The author's separate subsections respect precisely this difference. A future comparative lexicon would be more effective if it included a category such as 'different craft meanings of the same verb' alongside 'tools' and 'products'.

9. Chapter Six: Vocabulary of Other Traditional Caste-Associated Occupations (pp. 301–362)

Chapter Six (pp. 301–362) includes vocabulary connected with Kanu, Halwai, Teli, Mochiya, Dom/Dobar, Kuredi, Barai, Pasi, Suri, Kalwar, Laheri, Chamar, Mali, and other occupational communities. The category 'other' encompasses many occupations involving different materials, tools, operations, products, and social uses. It would be inappropriate to treat them as a homogeneous group: the chapter's variety displays the book's sociolinguistic reach.

Food production, oil extraction, leather work, basket making, services, and the making of other household goods each contain distinct networks of names for materials, tools, actions, products, and practices. This chapter shows the breadth of the book's social coverage. It also raises questions of representation: which occupations receive fuller treatment, which less, and is this because of the availability of sources or their historical importance? Answering these questions would require a separate count of entries by chapter.

Rather than drawing lexical boundaries on the basis of community names, a next stage of research should ask whether the same term is used among different communities. The designation 'caste-associated' cannot necessarily be taken as implying a monopoly over a particular occupation.

Kanu and Halwai: The Technical Language of Food

Pages 302–303 describe Kanu food materials, forms of parched grain, hearths, perforated utensils, sieves, and various names for farhi or lava. Here 'food' does not refer merely to raw ingredients but to the results of heating, puffing, roasting, sifting, mixing, and serving. The form of the same grain changes as the process changes; a technical sequence of meanings is consequently essential for understanding food culture.

The discussion of names such as bhuja, lava, farhi, and mar on page 303 shows that differing processes of food preparation generate distinct names. Each term should not, however, be treated as a universally applicable synonym for one botanical species or one heating procedure. Usage may vary geographically. A lexicon of food science should record the original kind of grain, method of heating, texture of the prepared food, and occasion of consumption.

The materials associated with Halwai work include references to milk, curd, the processing of sweets, cooking methods, vessels, and terms relating to purity. On page 320, the author mentions several local names for curd and the processes by which it is set. Terms for adding a starter, setting, or different stages of the process have important operational meanings in food technology. Although the general word 'curd' may suffice in ordinary speech, the practitioner may require different states of it for different purposes.

Teli Workers: Oil Presses, Oilseeds, and Products

On pages 320–321, the Teli occupation is linked to raw materials, oilseeds, the traditional oil press or kolhu, equipment for pressing oil, and the residue left behind. Four levels form one semantic field: names for parts of the press, varieties of oilseed, operations of extraction, and uses of the finished oil. It is useful to classify seeds brought from fields and the material remaining after extraction in relation to the same original substance, but their practical uses differ.

Oil pressing connects agriculture with household manufacture. As machinery develops, both the usage and meaning of older words associated with oil pressing may change.

Pasi Workers: Terms for Working with Palmyra and Date Palms

On pages 334–335, the author gives names for palmyra and date-palm trees, cut surfaces, vessels used to collect sap, climbing implements, different parts of the trees, and the actions of extracting their juice. Here the body of a plant itself becomes the workplace. The terms used in the work cannot be understood without distinguishing the parts of the tree. Differences between palmyra, date palm, coverings, cutting operations, and arrangements of vessels constitute a combined record of local botanical knowledge and occupational expertise.

Chamar Workers: Processes of Leather Craft

On pages 344–345, the book discusses leather materials, cut or prepared hides, cleansing, dyeing, cutting, joining, stitching, and finished leather goods. It separately records the stages of treating raw biological material and transforming it into durable objects through nouns and verbs. The central feature of artisans' knowledge is the alteration of a material's properties. Leatherwork cannot be understood merely through the names of its final products.

The treatment of other tools and varieties of leather on page 345 provides linguistic evidence of fine distinctions for changes in the material within this occupation. The evidence should be read as a record of historical craft knowledge. Caste-based prejudices associated with the work may be examined critically, but the original artisans' skills must not be overlooked.

Mochiya, Kuredi, Laheri, Barai, Mali, and the Remaining Communities

The work of Mochiya, Kuredi, Laheri, Barai, and Mali communities involves different kinds of materials and products: footwear or leather, baskets or cane, articles of ornament, betel leaves, and flowers. This variety means that a single chapter includes multiple semantic fields concerned with social services, domestic use, and craftsmanship.

Within the scope defined by the original author, the section brings together the practical techniques of a range of smaller occupations. A critical question is which occupations receive detailed material and which are treated relatively briefly. Such inequality of coverage does not necessarily indicate relative importance: regional interviews, the specialists accessible when the book was written, and the ease of documenting particular crafts may also have been factors. For now, one can only conjecture about these causes.

The Principal Achievement of Chapter Six's Vocabulary

The author includes under 'other traditional occupations' many occupational names that might otherwise have been excluded from the chapters organized around major materials. This section matters because language is made not only in craft workshops but also in kitchens, fields, markets, ponds, trees, households, and festivals. Its vocabulary, formed at many centres, widens the map of everyday production in Mithila.

10. Chapter Seven: Linguistic Considerations (pp. 363–393)

Chapter Seven seeks to transform the book's collected material into linguistic analysis. Its contents include words classified by etymology, origin, and meaning; polysemous words; words with their own independent meanings; synonyms; processes of word formation; alternative forms; problems of standardization; abbreviations; prefixes and suffixes; phonetics; vowel sounds and extra-short vowels; consonants and conjuncts; the number of letters in words; sound change; semantic change; and a conclusion.

10.1 Word Origins and Semantic Relationships

Occupational vocabulary may include indigenous sounds, forms adopted through contact with neighbouring languages, altered forms of older words, and new names arising from changes in craft practice. But similarity of sound alone is insufficient to declare that a word derives from Sanskrit, Hindi, Bengali, or Persian. Historical evidence, older occurrences, and regional distribution are required. Context is equally decisive in matters of polysemy and synonymy: the same tool name may denote different objects in different regions.

Conventional, Compositional, and Conventionally Specialized Words

On page 363, the author offers a threefold classification into rudha, yaugika, and yogarudha. In general, rudha refers to a word whose meaning is established through customary social use; yaugika stresses the combined meanings of its constituent parts; and yogarudha concerns a specialized meaning arising from a compound form. This classification is particularly important for occupational words because a name originally derived from a tool's shape or function may eventually become the fixed name of one specific implement.

From a critical perspective, identifying a word as compositional does not establish its historical derivation. Whether its constituent parts are transparent to present-day Maithili speakers is another question. This is an essential precaution in lexicology: each etymology associated with the author's examples requires evidence from different periods.

Synonyms and Singleness of Meaning: pp. 374–375

On pages 374–375, the author discusses synonymy and provides examples of several lexical groups, before beginning to describe processes of word formation. It would be mistaken to call several names for one object 'perfect synonyms' without qualification, since such names can differ in context, region, technical function, and emotional nuance. The author's listing of technical synonyms supplies preliminary material; a new lexicon could classify it more effectively by adding the region, speaking community, and differences in a tool's form or use.

A practical solution would be to cross-reference every current synonym from a principal entry without silently absorbing all variant forms into a single headword. 'Synonym' and 'variant form' are not always the same: a phonetic alteration may be a variant, while a difference in material or use may challenge the proposed limits of synonymy.

Word Formation and the Extension of Technical Forms

On page 375, the author connects the formation of many terms with the shape, colour, teeth, parts, actions, or material properties of tools. The research implication is that occupational naming is not arbitrary but an aspect of human categorization and recognition. An object resembling a tooth may take a name reflecting that resemblance; a cutting implement may be named

after the action it performs. The formation of any particular word, however, is not established by resemblance alone but requires independent examination of its accepted meaning.

Suffixes, Diminutives, and Variation

On pages 382–383, the author illustrates word-formation variants with lists of numerical and other multipurpose suffixes. In studying this material, one must remember that a single suffix need not carry the same sense in every word. One form may indicate smallness, another collectivity, and another may be a formation characteristic of a regional dialect. Expanding the linguistic analysis requires keeping separate accounts of proposed regularities and observed exceptions.

Phonetics and Standardization

The author examines regional pronunciation, vowels and consonants, combinations of sounds, and phonetic change in occupational terms. On page 392, semantic change is treated separately alongside examples of changes in sound. The collection contains various forms, but a drive to select a standard written term should not erase living pronunciation and thereby damage folk evidence. An appropriate dictionary would preserve the original written form with pronunciations, phonetic transcription if possible, and regional codes.

Not every regional form should be called a spelling error. Many vowel changes may reflect consistent systems within living linguistic traditions. Testing this requires more than comparing variants of one word: one must examine whether similar changes occur regularly across numerous words. The examples collected by the author furnish material for this investigation.

Semantic Broadening, Narrowing, and Shift

On pages 392–393, the author explains semantic broadening, narrowing, and shift. Occupational words are particularly rich examples of semantic change because newly designed tools, the decline of older objects, or the employment of an existing name in a new industry can alter the scope of a meaning. Where a word once covered a broad class of material but later refers only to a particular implement, semantic narrowing is possible; the reverse suggests broadening. These processes should not be imposed on every form without checking the chronology implicit in the original examples.

Chapter Seven's main achievement is to read an inventory of occupational vocabulary as a series of linguistic phenomena. Nevertheless, final decisions about many words' etymologies, multiple meanings, and standardization continue to require comparison between dated historical uses and regional evidence.

II. Conclusion (pp. 394–397)

A Close Reading of the Author's Own Conclusions

On pages 394–395, the author makes clear that the subject is exceedingly extensive and that the book has not been able to include every possible

occupation or every term in full detail. Nevertheless, he considers the collection of words for the raw materials, implements, products, division of operations, and qualities and defects of various occupations important. Reading this self-assessment suggests that the book should be presented not as 'the final all-inclusive lexicon' but as 'an initial, systematically organized foundation for research'.

On page 395, the author raises the prospect of changing means of labour, mechanization, decreasing use of older tools, and the disappearance of traditional words. The arrival of new terms alongside new products in several trades points to social change. Linguistic transformation here is not a 'mistake in vocabulary'; changes in materials and suitable implements are among its causes. This conclusion raises an especially pertinent question for language history: how can older terms, disappearing along with technical knowledge, be preserved through textual evidence?

12. Appendices: Community Lists, Proverbs, and Bibliography (from p. 398)

The first appendix is a 'List of Names Associated with Traditional Occupational Castes of Mithila' (p. 398). The contents identify the second as 'Certain Proverbs Concerning Occupational Castes' (p. 402), and the third as the 'List of Works Consulted' (p. 404). The list of community names helps cross-reference the social categories discussed in the main work, while the proverbs add a different level of evidence concerning practical meanings and social evaluations.

The Sociolinguistic Importance of the Appendices: Names and Folk Sayings

On pages 398–401, the list of names associated with occupational communities shows indications of grammatical feminine forms, subcastes or local titles, principal names, and particular deities. Page 398, for instance, includes Kalwar, Kasera, Kanu, Kumhar, Kuredi, Garedi, and Chamar, while pages 400–401 list Patwa, Pasi, Barai, Barhi, Mallah, Mali, Laheri, Lohar, Suri, Sonar, Halwai, and others. Some entries record several customary alternative names for one community. These facts reveal the social range of community names, but do not establish that every name remains a universally accepted form of contemporary self-identification.

Appendix B, comprising proverbs associated with occupational communities (from p. 402), supplies verbal evidence of society's practical perceptions. Praise, satire, criticism, and stereotype may occur within the same stock of popular sayings. It would be wrong to treat a proverb uncritically as historical fact or current social policy. A statement found in folk speech may indicate an evaluation held at a particular time; it is not a legitimate basis for defining an actual community.

The 'List of Works Consulted' begins on page 404. Pages 404–405 show references concerning Sanskrit and Prakrit, Hindi, and Maithili, and the list

continues afterwards. This apparatus connects the book's lexical collection with wider linguistic and literary traditions.

A Useful New Editorial Presentation of the Appendices

A future edition could supply two-way references between principal lexical entries and the community names in the appendices. From an artisan's name, for example, readers could reach associated tools, materials, actions, and products; conversely, from an implement they could reach the names of all the occupations in which it is used. Such a system would reduce the reproduction of rigid caste-centred boundaries and make the study of objects easier.

A separate critical index of the cited proverbs could record meaning, context, possible bias, figures of speech, and source. Republishing folk sayings requires a responsible approach to social dignity; derogatory utterances presented without context may mislead readers.

13. Chapter-by-Chapter Comparative Table

Chapter /Page	Principal Material or Field	Linguistic Focus
One, 55	Social and historical background	Occupations, caste, literature, classification
Two, 65	Wood and bamboo	Materials, cutting, tools, manufacture
Three, 133	Earth and water	Pottery, water transport, fish, makhana
Four, 195	Fibre and thread	Spinning wheel, warp and weft, loom, textiles
Five, 243		Blacksmiths, kasera workers, goldsmiths; craft operations
Six, 301	Various occupations	Food, oil, leather, baskets, others
Seven, 363	Linguistics	Etymology, meaning, sounds, standardization

14. Critical Evaluation of the Book

The book has three distinctive accomplishments: systematic collection of technical vocabulary from different areas of production; an attempt to relate artisans' language to its social and cultural background; and a linguistic examination of the collected terms. Its limitations also deserve consideration. The author himself acknowledges the collection's incompleteness; evidence for regional variants and their distribution is not uniformly established; and historical claims require comparisons across regions and periods. The book's value becomes clear when achievements and limitations are considered together.

Critical Questions

For which words are geographical dialect, speaker, and year of collection explicitly documented?

Does the same word retain the same meaning across different occupations, or does its meaning change?

How widely are the collected words distributed socially, and where are they only individual or local usages?

How should one understand the unequal extent of the chapters organized around major materials and the chapter on 'other occupations'?

How can contemporary occupational changes and the names for artisans' new equipment be documented?

15. Directions for Further Research

Many difficulties of interpretation could be reduced if a critical lexicon based on this book recorded, with each entry, the original word, pronunciation, alternative forms, part of speech, meaning, occupation, category as object, tool, action or product, region and informant, reference to the page in the book, and verified visual or audio evidence of the object or activity. Such a systematic format could make relationships among the collected terms clearer.

The next stage should include a comparative index organized by material, counts of entries in each chapter, field surveys of gendered divisions of labour, meanings of identical words across occupations, and independent review of evidence concerning language contact. Rather than begin with conclusions predetermined by caste, research should make artisans' own statements, direct observation of tools, and local economic history its primary evidence.

Impartial Editing of Synonyms and Variant Pronunciations

In many places the original chapters give alternatives in a 'form/form' construction. These may represent only differences of pronunciation, synonyms, differences of objects, or geographical variants. Choosing one written form and deleting the others would impoverish the language. Four questions must accompany each form: 'where', 'by whom', 'in what sense', and 'in relation to which tool or task'. Marking unclear evidence as 'unverified' is more scientific than inventing a meaning through guesswork.

Visual Records of Objects and Oral Evidence

Without seeing the construction of a carpenter's plane, a textile loom, a blacksmith's striking tool, or a Pasi worker's vessel for collecting sap, it is difficult to grasp subtle distinctions in technical meanings. An extended investigation combining measurements of objects, artisans' statements, visual records of work sequences, and sound recordings of local pronunciations would reveal the connections between words and operations more clearly.

16. Conclusion

Dr Yoganand Jha's The Vocabulary of Traditional Caste-Associated Occupations in Maithili is a notable effort to organize the specialized linguistic world that has developed among labour, materials, production, and social practice in Maithili-speaking regions. Its central strength lies in refusing to isolate words from folk life. From wood and bamboo through earth and water, thread, metal, and numerous occupations, the classification records not only meanings but also the technical structure of operations. Chapter Seven's linguistic analysis links this material to the wider study of language.

From a critical standpoint, the book should be studied as a primary source for local knowledge, while its sociolinguistic generalizations remain subject to independent verification. It provides foundational materials for the history of Maithili occupational vocabulary, traditional craftsmanship, and the development of dictionaries.

CHAPTER 09 / 2010

Stories and Folktales

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

Stories and Folktales is a collection of Maithili prose by Dr Yoganand Jha that brings together, within a single volume, contemporary socio-political stories, brief narratives translated from literature in other Indian languages, and tales grounded in popular belief. The original publication page identifies 2010 as the year of publication, Mithila Research Society of Kabilpur–Laheriasarai, Darbhanga, as publisher, a print run of five hundred copies, a price of one hundred rupees, and Shekhar Prakashan, Patna, as printer. These details come from the book's own publication record, not from external conjecture. The author's signed statement on original p. 30 is dated 22 May 2010. [Original opening publication page; p. 30]

The book's sequence makes its classification explicit. Under 'Original' appear 'Shastra-Chinta' (p. 35), 'Faisla' (p. 41), and 'Sapanak Dak' (p. 50). Under 'Translated' are 'The Path of Self-Respect' (p. 57), 'Each One's Water' (p. 59), 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' (p. 61), 'A Felicitation Volume' (p. 62), and 'The Rare Satyanarayan Worship' (p. 63). Under 'Folkloric Narratives' are 'Dhanak Haruri' (p. 65), 'Seven Sisters' (p. 70), and 'Beniram' (p. 77). Finally, 'A Brief Genealogy of Kabilpur' begins on p. 89. Thus all eleven stories in the original collection receive individual treatment here. [Original p. 31, contents]

The available original is a photographic reproduction without a searchable text layer. The present study therefore relies upon words visible in the story images, titles, footnotes, and paragraph sequence. Matters verifiable only from external evidence are kept distinct from the book's internal evidence. No facts about a character, time, event, or motive for composition have been added without support in the source. Interpretations of meaning and critical

evaluations belong to the reviewer; they are not presented as direct pronouncements by the original author.

The conjunction of 'stories' and 'folktales' is itself the collection's central critical question. The original stories give form to personal experience, institutional pressures, and the conflicts of contemporary society. The translated short-short narratives have compressed structures, recognizable aims, and often aphoristic endings. Folkloric narratives depend on collective memory, vernacular ethics, and symbols of belief. It would therefore be unsound to judge all three forms by one artistic standard. Only by respecting these differences can the collection's achievements and limitations be properly assessed.

2. Introduction, Foreword, and Records of the Maithili Short-Story Movement

The volume opens with an extended essay, 'Let a Lamp Burn Through the Night of Conflict: A Quiet Revolution in Maithili Story Writing.' It would be mistaken to regard it simply as Dr Yoganand Jha's personal account of writing. It also documents the development of a programme of public meetings, story readings, and discussion among Maithili short-story writers. The essay recalls plans made at the end of 1989, the first event in 1990, the fiftieth programme in 2004, and subsequent initiatives. Its literary purpose is clearly identified: to give emerging writers opportunities to read their stories aloud, obtain immediate reactions, build literary connections, and use the language in public. [Original pp. 5–12]

The distinctive feature of this enterprise is not merely the number of authors or listeners but the listener's role in the process of literary creation. Public readings of written stories, collective responses, debate, and the possibility of revision reveal the social life of prose. The original essay, however, is predominantly appreciative of the organizers' contribution. It would not be appropriate to regard all the programme's historical effects as fully established on that basis alone. Attendance registers, original programmes, contemporary newspapers, and independent testimonies from participants could make it a firmer source for literary history. The account within the collection should be read as evidence supplied by its organizers.

The 'Foreword', published under the name of Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman', situates the author's literary practice in the geographical and literary surroundings of Laheriasarai and Kabilpur. It illuminates ancient sites in Kabilpur, local temples, communal occasions, public memory, and a number of writers and scholars. In places it offers sequences of names and works resembling a bibliography; elsewhere it draws a social portrait from the writer's experience. Its literary significance lies in connecting the story collection with its author's literary community and institutional background. [Original pp. 13–30]

The foreword's length is both an asset and a structural incongruity. It preserves in one place numerous indications of the institutional foundations

of Maithili literature, women's education, folk singing, journals, drama, translation, and village cultural activities. Yet before reaching the stories themselves, the reader must travel through a long account of regional literary activity; the book's opening momentum turns towards institutional history rather than narration. Even so, this material cannot be neglected by researchers, since it makes clearer the intellectual terrain of the author's collection and study of folklore.

Pages 24–27 refer to many local writers, journals, translations, educational institutions, and episodes in the Maithili literary movement. Independent records would be needed to verify these historical claims; nevertheless, they are significant elements in the collection's self-presentation. The book does not ask its audience merely to follow plots. It places itself within a communal effort to create, collect, circulate, and preserve Maithili prose. In this qualified sense, Stories and Folktales is a cultural document as well as a creative literary work.

3. Original Stories: From Individual Consciousness to Public Crisis

3.1 'Shastra-Chinta': Dreams, Sacred Texts, and the Conflict of National Insecurity (original pp. 35–40)

The story opens with a terrifying dream. Anxieties concerning the nation, history, society, and his own existence return repeatedly to the protagonist. The author does not confine them to the reporting of a single sudden political event. Within the dream's background, concerns about geographical borders, internal disintegration, social division, and collective security become intertwined. After the dream, the protagonist's daily life moves among books, periodicals, religious reading, national concerns, and self-examination. This psychological organization makes the piece more an idea-driven narrative than an eventful realist story. [Original pp. 35–37]

The books surrounding the protagonist, including the Gita and Ramayana, together with scriptural citations and writing materials, shape a particular intellectual personality. Distressed by violence and disorder, he finds that religious reading alone cannot quiet his agitation. The question becomes one of the relationship between scriptural learning, civic duty, and defensive resistance. The original title 'Shastra-Chinta' allows a critical connection between the study of scripture and its purpose in public life. 'Shastra' here is not simply a synonym for 'shastra' in the sense of a weapon; nevertheless, as the story develops, concern about learning turns towards measures of security and resistance.

The arrival of a young man named Ashok marks a decisive turn. Initially respectful towards his teacher, he soon raises questions about the nation's danger, weakness, the hazards of being unarmed, and resistance to injustice. The protagonist invokes nonviolence, truth, restraint, and the moral path, whereas Ashok asks whether goodwill by itself can suffice. References to the Gita and arguments about punishment, the defence of righteousness, and duty

are drawn into their exchange until the narrative becomes a direct confrontation of two positions. [Original pp. 38–39]

On the final page the protagonist does not reject Ashok's reasoning unconditionally; he returns to the tension between scriptural books and questions of national security. The dream image, disturbed by the possibility of a collective assault, also returns at the end. Thus the story stops not at a fixed declaration of a solution but at a coherent representation of fear and vigilance. [Original p. 40] 'Peace' and 'security' here are not opposed slogans; they emerge as values under pressure within the narrative.

The story's strength lies in articulating an intellectually engaged person's mental perplexity through dialogue. Its limitation is that, at several points, a broad national and social crisis is described in argumentative statements rather than through specific events and fully realized characters. Ashok becomes the representative of a questioning position; little of his independent life appears. Agreement with the tale's fierce ideological concerns is not required for critical appreciation. What matters is that the writer confronts classical morality with the pressing need for social protection. A footnote mentions an earlier publication in 2002: the collection's date of 2010 must therefore not be mistaken for the story's date of composition. [Original p. 40, footnote]

3.2 'Faisla': The Office, Justice, Family, and Political Pressure (original pp. 41–49)

Faisla ('The Decision') begins with an envelope marked 'Confidential' and an official report. At once, the relationship between information and the power to decide occupies the narrative centre. Descriptions of the private residence of the government officer Raghavji, his wife Jamuni Devi, their educated children, and social standing evoke a household whose financial security and status depend upon administrative office. Although the home looks stable from outside, Raghavji is inwardly disturbed by a decision he must make. The writer places domestic conversation alongside the responsibilities of public office. [Original pp. 41–44]

Jamuni Devi is not a decorative character. Observing her husband's distraction, she asks its cause and advances arguments based on the family's needs, their children's future, and the security of his employment. Raghavji's sense of human responsibility collides with Jamuni Devi's practical concerns. It would be wrong to treat her merely as a symbol of moral ignorance: her fears arise from real familial dependence and the material conditions of earning a living. Nonetheless, the story leaves the central power of decision with the male official, whereas Jamuni's independent social perspective could have been developed further.

With the entrance of Malapur's temple, its mahant, local residents, land, and a public demonstration, the private dilemma becomes an administrative and political question. Competing land claims, rural protests, police action, injury to the crowd, and political pressure form interrelated layers. Pages 46–

49 show the circumstances in which an official report is prepared, contradictions within local dominance, and interference from different levels of authority. This is not simply the story of 'one bad officer'. The system is so constituted that the language of facts, political advantage, and anxiety about a career pull the same decision in different directions.

The title Faisla appears to promise an unambiguous moral verdict, yet the actual narrative gives greater weight to the pressures within the decision-making process. The officer's written report, his attempt to justify it, and his helplessness before political connections persist to the end. Without further evidence, therefore, the last developments cannot be proclaimed a 'reform of the system' or 'complete justice'. The distance between the questions arising in the character's mind and what he actually does is itself a critical meaning of the story. [Original pp. 45–49]

In terms of narrative craft, the confidential document, the exchanges with his wife, administrative recollection, the report, and scenes of a protesting crowd provide the principal movement. Dialogue conveys background information, although characters sometimes seem to express the author's moral reasoning more than their own spontaneous lives. Compared with the first original story, which unfolds against an abstract sense of national crisis, Faisla's social crisis is relatively concrete: offices, paperwork, land, a temple, a crowd, and the channels of power. An original footnote records an earlier publication in 2003, authentic evidence of its subsequent inclusion in the collection. [Original p. 49, footnote]

3.3 'Sapanak Dak': Land Records and Rural Insecurity (original pp. 50–54)

The central character in Sapanak Dak is Sukhlal. Economic instability, attachment to his village, and a sense of belonging to ancestral land provide the foundations of his life. The narrative shows that a community's memory of ownership and the documentary law of land can be two different things. Long possession by Sukhlal's family, or the remembered names of his forebears, may give him personal confidence, but the absence of official records makes his rights precarious. Amid village relationships, old acquaintances, and social standing, the question of land becomes steadily more difficult. [Original pp. 50–52]

Mohan's arrival brings into focus the complexities of land measurement, purchases and sales, and registered records. Names in government offices, possible fraudulent papers, oral claims of entitlement, and participants in land transactions all intensify the tension. Sukhlal fears not only the loss of money but the destruction of inherited memory and the foundation of his home. Amid this psychological pressure, the 'dream' is not a simple event of sleep: it becomes a literary form of rural insecurity. [Original pp. 52–53]

In the last section, an anxious Sukhlal is caught in the world of offices and papers as he tries to save the land. The boundary between waking and dreaming becomes blurred, and a devastating dream image involving the village finally unsettles him. Rather than providing a complete judicial

resolution of the dispute, the author depicts its psychological consequences. The title's word 'dak' may be read as a metaphor for a message or warning of impending crisis; it should not be mistaken for a plot about the functioning of the postal service. [Original pp. 53–54]

Read together, Faisla and Sapanak Dak expose two faces of administrative paperwork: in one, an official decides through documents; in the other, an ordinary villager suffers through their absence. This double construction yields an informal critique of the relations between state, law, and citizen. Sapanak Dak is concise in form, turning its action distinctly towards Sukhlal's unease. Its limitation is that the intricate legal processes behind land rights are not shown in detail. The purpose is to produce literary experience, not an account of court procedure. A footnote records the story's earlier publication in 2003. [Original p. 54]

4. Translated Stories: Moral Reasoning within Brief Narratives

The translated section contains five pieces. To present all five as independently original stories by Dr Yoganand Jha would be a factual error of literary history. According to the original footnotes, 'The Path of Self-Respect' and 'Each One's Water' were translated from Dr (Mrs) Mithilesh Kumari Mishra's Hindi short-story collection Chhantta Kohra. Footnotes to the other three indicate translations from her Sanskrit collection of miniature stories. Several appeared in Maithili journals before entering this volume, as the footnotes also record. Parallel, line-by-line texts of the Hindi and Sanskrit originals were not available for this review. Accordingly, it does not claim to decide conclusively whether the translations remain faithful to, or deviate from, those sources; it examines the literary operation of the Maithili texts actually available. [Original pp. 58, 60–63, footnotes]

4.1 'The Path of Self-Respect': Convenience versus Self-Worth (original pp. 57–58)

Against the setting of an examination or selection process, a conversation between young men raises questions about opportunity, reservations, eligibility, and self-respect. One speaker points to the possibility of securing an advantage, whereas another emphasizes selection through confidence in his ability and work. The concluding statement establishes dignity and personal effort as the principal moral values. No detailed family histories are provided; the story draws its energy from brief exchanges and a decisive utterance. [Original pp. 57–58]

The literary effect comes from the opposition created between benefiting from an external provision and maintaining moral confidence in one's own labour. Yet that opposition does not amount to a complete argument about public policy. The historical reasons for reservation, structural inequalities of opportunity, and the experiences of different communities are not examined in the miniature narrative. It is therefore more reasonable to read the character's position as an expression of literary self-respect than to turn it into

a definitive policy judgement on the distribution of opportunity throughout Indian society. That would extract more from the text than it supports.

The impact of the Maithili translation comes from the immediacy of dialogue, the pace of question and answer, and the brief closing statement. Without access to the Hindi original, it is impossible to compare literal with sense-based translation in detail. In the Maithili text, however, the central thought is conveyed without linguistic obscurity. Like the other aphoristic narratives in this section, it presents a short scene of moral choice.

4.2 'Each One's Water': Who Has Rights over Natural Resources? (original pp. 59–60)

The arrival of a sage, the conduct of a king, and questions surrounding the use of water supply the essentials of this miniature tale. Royal power treats water distribution as a matter for its own decision, whereas the sage distinguishes between water brought by an individual and water occurring in nature. The story thereby asks how far any particular person or ruler can legitimately claim moral authority over natural resources indispensable to human life. At the end the king's understanding changes, and he accepts the principle that natural water is available for collective use. [Original pp. 59–60]

A satisfactory critical reading must go beyond 'the king is bad, the sage is good'. The king represents the institutional power of the state; the sage, individual judgement and the public good. The king's change depicts the acceptance of a popular moral principle by political authority. Because everyone needs water, the narrative rises above any one region or caste. For all its brevity, it asks an exacting question about nature, common life, and ownership.

Dialogue, repeated reasoning, and a straightforward reversal of judgement dominate the form. The problem is not unfolded into a complex policy question; the author quickly changes the king's mind in order to communicate a direct moral understanding. This economy is a strength of the miniature tale, but it leaves room for a fuller picture of the social and economic realities of unequal water distribution.

4.3 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam': The World as Family, Put to the Test of Conduct (original p. 61)

This extremely brief story introduces a Bengali young man who has gone to England for higher studies, his English friend, and a family context. The dialogue addresses personal comfort, food, expenditure, the resources required for living, and duty towards others. The Sanskrit saying Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam ('the world is one family') becomes the title and offers an ideal to the reader, while the characters test its meaning in practice. [Original p. 61]

The critical centre is not simply praise of the aphorism but an examination of its application. The assertion that the whole world is a family becomes meaningful only when an ethical relation between one's own convenience and the welfare of strangers is acknowledged. In a brief exchange shaped by differences of language, country, and family, the story gestures towards a

cosmopolitan sensibility; nevertheless, rather than elaborating the issue, it leaves the question open.

From the standpoint of translation, keeping a Sanskrit expression such as Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam unchanged while arranging Maithili dialogue around it exemplifies a multilingual cultural setting. The translated Maithili work thus carries ideas originating in Hindi or Sanskrit into the world of Maithili readers. No claim can be made, however, about a particular strategy of translation without comparing the exact verbal form of the source.

4.4 'A Felicitation Volume': Official Honours and Actual Writing (original p. 62)

A minister visits a school. Because of an earlier connection, teachers and students arrange to honour him. The headmaster presents an 'Abhinandan Granth', or felicitation volume; when the person being honoured asks about what has been written in it, its hollowness is exposed. The satire suggests that the splendour of a ceremony does not, by itself, prove any intellectual achievement. [Original p. 62]

For literary society, the miniature tale raises a particularly useful question. If a volume contains no genuine work or study, only a cover, welcoming remarks, and token material, there is a distance between the prestige attached to the word 'book' and what the object actually contains. The tale sharply satirizes this distance. The value of a publication issued in honour of someone who has attained office must be assessed through its actual content. The social pressure surrounding a ceremony cannot substitute for critical discrimination.

The structure rests on a comic and satirical reversal: first the ostentation of the welcome, then an examination of the volume, and finally an outcome contrary to the audience's expectation. There is little space in this miniature sequence for extensive character development. Nevertheless, the questions it raises about education, politics, and book culture also permit a critical look at the actual traditions of literary honour recorded in the collection's extended foreword. This intertextual irony contains an intriguing possibility of self-criticism within the book.

4.5 'The Rare Satyanarayan Worship': From Ritual to Truthful Conduct (original p. 63)

The story consists of a dialogue between a devotee who wishes to arrange a Satyanarayan observance and a priest. On hearing of the devotee's private troubles and desire for religious ritual, the priest stresses truth, upright conduct, and the welfare of others. Rather than simply rejecting outward ceremonial arrangements, the story asks why worship of truth should be regarded as separate from one's actual conduct of life. [Original p. 63]

This is a voice of ethical reinterpretation arising from within religious tradition itself. The priest does not restrict his vocation to collecting ritual materials and directing ceremonies; he treats the practice of truth in life as the fundamental criterion. The result is a fresh question for readers about the

meaning of devotion. This is not a wholesale rejection of religious belief but a discussion of priorities between ceremonial practice and conduct.

The word 'rare' in the title poses a question: is the occasion of ritual worship rare, or is the courage to abide by truth rare? The text guides the reader towards the second meaning. In a single page the story makes its idea clear. Yet the complexity of the devotee's family troubles has little room to develop; the moral principle dominates the scene. In this way the work exhibits both the didactic character and the formal compression of translated Maithili miniature fiction.

4.6 Shared Achievements and Research Limitations of the Translated Section

A common compositional method is visible in all five miniatures: a small incident of life is followed by arguments from two sides and concludes with an explicit value or an ironic turn. Self-respect, water, the world as family, ceremonial honour, and truthful conduct are five distinct subjects, but all attack the gap between words and actions. Maithili translation brings these thoughts into the experience of Maithili readers. The brief form swiftly carries readers to the centre of each argument; it also limits the possibility of psychological complexity and contextual development.

The original footnotes provide useful indications of the works translated, an editorial strength. For the purposes of research, however, a complete comparative register identifying the source editions, publication information in the original languages, original titles, and textual variants would make a historical critique of the translations more dependable. This study does not attempt to fill the absence with imagined quotations or unspecified source texts.

5. Folkloric Narratives: Food, Solidarity, and the Folk Memory of Deities

The designation 'folkloric narrative' is no accident. The pieces in this section have the oral manner of folktale-telling, but they do not appear to be merely verbatim transcripts of oral lore. At times the writer provides an explanatory background before the tale begins; elsewhere he appends explicit conclusions about its social meaning, or offers his own reflections on the historical possibility of a deity tradition or genealogy. It is essential, therefore, to distinguish material inherited from oral tradition from its literary reconstruction when calling these pieces 'folktales'.

5.1 'Dhanak Haruri': Grain, Hunger, and an Ethics of Coexistence (original pp. 65–69)

At the opening the writer reflects on the place of food and rice. The expectation that a Brahmin will be fed, references to the origin of paddy, and a discussion of the importance of grain establish an intellectual background drawn from popular belief. This makes clear the cultural importance of human nourishment, while the principal narrative tests human self-interest

through the lives of birds. A king, a queen, and a community of bahikari birds participate in the account of 'Dhanak Haruri'. [Original pp. 65–66]

The queen repeatedly obtains food for the family and community, while the king assumes his right to consume it without question. In a few simple scenes, the story reveals dependence for nourishment, the unequal distribution of service, and the undervaluing of another's labour. The queen's dissatisfaction is not merely a private sulk; it is a response to the one-sided exploitation of work in the name of affection. The king is unable to arrange his own food and thus finds his sense of entitlement in conflict with circumstances. [Original pp. 66–67]

At a crucial turn, the king's trust in the queen, her independent decision, and his distress carry the narrative into tragedy. Resolutions to give up food, to fast, or to part company, together with compassion and regret, transform this from a simple tale of the origin of paddy into an account of mutual responsibility within marriage and communal life. In the concluding pages the author comments on the wider human implications of the folktale amid the queen's separation and the king's grief. The final paragraph also mentions a belief associated with China; it would therefore be improper, without independent regional evidence, to declare the tale exclusively indigenous to Mithila. [Original pp. 67–69]

The form mixes folkloric explanation with narrative. The initial discussion of grain determines the story's symbolic field but also delays the beginning of the dramatic action. The social behaviour of the bird characters reflects human social structures: king, queen, work, entitlement, care, and separation. The tale's chief strength is the way it brings into view both the material value of food and the otherwise invisible labour of obtaining it.

In his closing observations the writer draws attention to the folktale's compassion, altruism, and love. A critical caution is necessary here: its ethical suggestion should not be confined to an ideal of female self-sacrifice. The queen's labour, discontent, and desire for a life of her own make the story more complex. A renewed reading can distinguish women's experience, the moral meaning of work, and questions of collective food security. An original footnote records publication in an issue of Maithili Akademi Patrika in 2008. [Original p. 69]

5.2 'Seven Sisters': Female Solidarity in Adversity and the Triumph of Ingenuity (original pp. 70–76)

The first part opens with the author's short discussion of the creative nature of folktales. A folktale, he suggests, communicates the collective experiences, customs, thought, and traditions of ordinary people. On this premise he tells the story of seven sisters. In a poor family there are seven daughters. A shortage of food and domestic distress create circumstances in which the sisters must go away from their home towards the forest. The sequence of their names, their journey together, and their insistence on staying with one another have the distinctive cadence of oral storytelling. [Original pp. 70–71]

Within the forest, hunger, fear, an unfamiliar refuge, and the search for food intensify the conflict. The sisters arrive at a place that initially seems to promise nourishment and safety, but the same surroundings hold the threat of deceit and violence. The story introduces a terrifying figure resembling a witch, a dark house, a gate, and secret stratagems. The youngest sister's intelligence and the sisters' efforts to save one another become decisive. [Original pp. 72–73]

In the latter half the sisters try, one after another, to escape danger. They must jump, climb, hide, open gates, or confront obstructions. The narrative repeatedly shows that individual and collective safety cannot be separated. A sister who advances remains mindful of the one behind; cooperation continues through separation, hurt, and threatened violence. At the end the storyteller singles out the sisters' unity as the moral element of the tale. [Original pp. 73–76]

The number 'seven' shapes the folktale's form: a sequence of seven characters, recurrent danger, the different reactions of the sisters, and a shared conclusion. Their separate psychologies are not developed at great length, but their collective character is powerful. The forest becomes the place of external peril; a house may offer either security or danger; the witch personifies fear. It would be an error to treat such elements as literal history of contemporary social events. Within folktales they commonly function as instruments of symbolic meaning.

A social interpretation must attend not only to female helplessness but also to women's intelligence and collective resistance. The opening material deprivation exposes a failure of family protection, whereas in the final conflict the sisters discover their own means of defence. This change makes the work not merely a tale of pathos but a folknarrative of courage. A footnote records its publication in Mithila Darpan in 2008, evidence of its printed circulation. [Original p. 76]

5.3 'Beniram': A Village Deity, Caste Memory, and the Making of Folk History (original pp. 77–88)

Among the eleven pieces, Beniram is distinguished by its length, breadth of subject, and cultural complexity. The opening connects Beniram with the popular religious beliefs of two communities in Mithila, the Nau and Karori. His worship as a folk deity, cattle and their rearing, beliefs about magic and sorcery, and village security locate a specific field of collective memory. An opening section resembling a folk song and the subsequent narrative of events combine to create the popular voice of that belief. [Original pp. 77–79]

The original account successively introduces Raj Paraul, Lekha Thakur, Indra-Kavilas, Godhan Sati, and many events concerning Beniram's birth and life. Lekha Thakur's religious practice, the relationship between teacher and disciple, Godhan Sati's fidelity, and miraculous events must be understood as elements of folk narrative, not information confirmed by historical scholarship. Various beliefs, maxims, communal recollections, and wonders

are part of the story's own world. To equate them with established modern historical facts would distort the nature of the work. [Original pp. 80–82]

Through Godhan Sati's life, hostility involving Jasiya and Barsiya, magic and counter-magic, obstacles connected with marriage, and a sequence of birth and upbringing, the story creates a structure of female existence and motherhood rooted in popular belief. Godhan Sati's sense of duty, ability to take risks, and determination to protect her son are major forces driving the plot. At the same time, women's folk religious obligations are connected with the traditional ideal of satitva, or wifely chastity. Modern criticism must ask how much this ideal recognizes women's bravery and how far it restricts their independent social agency. [Original pp. 81–85]

After Beniram's birth, scenes involving knowledge of his father, family separation, youth, forests, dangerous animals, and encounters with malign powers give the tale an increasingly heroic-ballad character. His courage is not merely a display of personal strength: it appears as action undertaken to protect the family, confront injustice, and gain standing in the village community. In several episodes, tantric forces, sorcery, recourse to deities, and miracles continue to govern the story's world. [Original pp. 84–87]

The final part turns to Beniram's identity as a folk deity, beliefs associated with Dinanath, the protection of cattle, and the collective welfare of the village. In closing, the author himself indicates that Beniram's tale discloses numerous historical and cultural aspects. The assertion can be treated as material for understanding popular belief. Definitive historical confirmation, however, would require comparative research into local worship, independently circulating versions of songs, accounts of oral narrators, and documentary records. [Original pp. 87–88]

Beniram derives its literary power from a multilayered plot. Unlike the tiny translated tales, it interweaves lineages, the worship of goddesses, sung narrative, religion, caste, gender, and the economy of livestock. Folk songs give the text the sound of oral transmission. Yet the absence of complete information about the narrator, place of collection, informants, and variant versions makes it difficult to treat this book as a definitive scholarly edition of the folktale. The soundest procedure would be to regard its text as one documented version and compare it with others.

5.4 The Comparative Significance of the Three Folkloric Narratives

Dhanak Haruri raises questions about grain and reciprocal labour; Seven Sisters portrays disruption caused by hunger and the sisters' collective self-defence; Beniram elaborates a cultural conception of a folk deity who protects his community. All three are linked by the 'preservation of life'. In the first, preservation depends on the availability of food and the just distribution of affection; in the second, on solidarity and ingenuity; in the third, on moral courage, belief in deities, and folk memory. The coexistence of these different means reveals several currents of popular life.

If these narratives are regarded as nothing but ancient and marvellous material, their present-day implications will disappear. Food scarcity, endangered girls, domestic labour, caste relations, livestock, and beliefs about village deities remain in conversation with human concerns today. Yet while drawing ethical significance from folklore, the critic must not assume that the social hierarchies, ideals of femininity, or miraculous beliefs depicted are automatically true or just. Asking appropriate questions is also part of a respectful study of popular tradition.

6. Appendix: The Form and Reliability of 'A Brief Genealogy of Kabilpur'

According to the contents, 'A Brief Genealogy of Kabilpur' begins on p. 89. The final pages of the available copy contain hand-drawn or diagrammatic family trees, branching sequences of names, and kinship connections. Placing such genealogical material immediately after the stories is unusual. It directly reflects the author's village-centred interests and his attempt to preserve caste and family memory alongside local history. [Original p. 89 and subsequent genealogical charts; reproduction pp. 46–50]

The importance of these family charts lies in the names and relationships they record, but the level of verification must be made explicit. Which name occurs on which branch is direct evidence from the book. It cannot be inferred simply by looking at a diagram that every relationship is historically verified. Oral family traditions, older surviving documents, genealogical registers, dates, and independent evidence of descent would have to be examined. Some charts and names are printed vertically or rotated; producing a verbatim transcription of every name without a legible original would be risky.

In literary terms, the appendix has a particular relationship with the three folkloric narratives. A tale such as Beniram gives meaning to a village deity and the communal memory of ancestry, while the family tree displays the documentary side of the same interest. The book, however, does not offer a sufficiently separate critical account of the relationship between story and genealogy. Introductions to each chart, source details, estimated periods, standardized names, and textual notes on illegible passages would make this appendix more useful for research in a future edited edition.

7. An Overall Examination of Language, Syntax, Dialogue, and Narrative Method

The language combines conversational Maithili, literary prose, Sanskrit-derived cultural vocabulary, and folk idioms. Shastra-Chinta concentrates words associated with religion, the nation, ethics, and philosophy. Faisla uses the language of offices, reports, employment, administration, and political connections. Sapanak Dak foregrounds fields, documents, possession, ancestral land, and village transactions. Vocabulary changes in keeping with the subject.

This is not decorative verbal abundance: it serves to identify the social domain of each fictional world. [Original pp. 35–54]

Shastra-Chinta has a questioning and abstract narrative voice. The protagonist interrogates himself; Ashok responds with ethical counter-questions. Repeated phrasing reveals a cycle of thought, although at times the narrative approaches a prolonged sermon. In Faisla the connection between inner life and marital dialogue is more natural: the wife's questions show how a crisis of office enters the home. Sapanak Dak gains intensity by combining anxiety about land with dialogue and dreams. The three original stories do not share one verbal rhythm; each adapts its form to its subject.

The translated miniatures generally follow a pattern of 'question, answer, moral consequence'. The narrator offers little extended description of setting; dialogue between two figures makes the central meaning clear. In A Felicitation Volume the satire springs from the final reversal, whereas in The Rare Satyanarayan Worship the distinction between formal ritual and truthful conduct is compressed into the closing words. The effect is swift understanding, but the critic must also ask whether the clarity of principle sometimes overpowers the characters' multidimensional psychology.

The language of the folkloric narratives moves in another direction. In Seven Sisters, repetition, numbered succession, simple warnings, and the rapid rhythm of escape create the effect of oral narration. In Dhanak Haruri, a popular conception of food determines the tale's opening framework. Beniram becomes polyphonic through songs, names of local deities, kinship relations, tantric terminology, and miracles. Reducing these differences to one uniform 'modern story style' would erase the collection's creative variety.

Literary criticism is not served by indiscriminately replacing local forms such as 'chhalah/chhalani', 'ahan/hamar', and 'kael/bhel', or their regional pronunciations, in the name of linguistic purity. Native speech, characters' expressions, and the sound of folk songs should be preserved. Certain matters of punctuation, the typesetting of titles, consistent proper names, and textual organization could be corrected in a new edition, with editorial notes. Spots and blemishes are visible in the photographic reproduction; it would be wrong to attribute them to the author's use of language.

8. Three Forms in One Collection: Story, Translation, and Folklore

The order of the collection's three sections is itself meaningful: first the individual grappling with the public crises of a new age, then translated stories offering compressed moral judgements, and finally tales of collective memory and popular belief. This is not a fixed chronology of historical periods, but it creates an order of reading experience: from abstract anxiety to social conduct, from conduct to didactic judgement, and thence to the extended memory of communities. The conjunction of 'story' and 'folktale' in the title accords with this actual compositional plan.

Characters in the original stories have relatively greater independence: Ashok disagrees with his teacher, Jamuni Devi questions her husband's inward

struggle, and Sukhlal is troubled by the insecurity of documents. In translated miniatures, figures commonly embody choices between values. Folktale characters operate as collective symbols and cultural roles. Accordingly, demanding the uniform psychological portraiture of modern fiction from Beniram, or novelistic expansion over twelve pages from A Felicitation Volume, would be a critical imbalance.

The sections nevertheless have deep connections. Duty in Shastra-Chinta, self-determination in The Path of Self-Respect, the primacy of conduct in The Rare Satyanarayan Worship, and collective obligation in Seven Sisters all ask, through different literary means, about the gap between saying and doing. The uncertainty of land rights in Sapanak Dak, common rights to natural resources in Each One's Water, and the distribution of grain in Dhanak Haruri offer different forms of the question of resources and justice. Institutional pressure in Faisla and communal faith in a guardian in Beniram present contrasting visions of power and security.

One limitation concerns the editorial proportions of the book. The three original stories are comparatively expansive, the five miniatures finish in very little space, and Beniram, in the third section, is again a narrative of many pages. This is natural to their different genres but creates sharp changes in reading rhythm. The introduction is also lengthy in comparison with the principal narrative section. A scholarly edition could turn these inequalities into strengths, without deleting any original material, by providing brief explanations of genre, source notes, and an account of the sequence.

9. Women, Class, Caste, and Power: Questions within the Texts

In Faisla, Jamuni Devi struggles between the security of her household and her husband's moral choice. This makes the woman a genuine party to the family structure, but her role remains restricted when the final decision is made. The queen in Dhanak Haruri reacts to the unequal division of food-producing labour and affection. In Seven Sisters, mutual solidarity among female characters becomes a means of safety. Beniram's Godhan Sati has loyalty and extraordinary courage, yet the cultural model of the 'sati' determines the meaning of her life. These are four different situations of women; an identical mould of the 'ideal woman' should not be imposed upon them all.

Class appears at several levels. Sukhlal's inherited memory of land is endangered by the lack of paperwork; Raghavji, despite his administrative position, experiences pressure from political authority; poor residents of Malapur bear the effects of collective conflict; and hunger initially causes the family's disintegration in Seven Sisters. Poverty here is not merely an adjective intended to produce pity: it is a force shaping human relationships and social opportunity.

At its outset Beniram records the beliefs of different caste communities concerning a folk deity, important material for studying popular religion. Yet the claim that particular groups worship Beniram is a record of local belief,

not a licence for sweeping assertions about their present conduct or the entire region's history. Actual research would need to hear diverse versions of the balance of caste power, rights to worship, priestly traditions, the protection of cattle, and local memories of lineage. The tale opens these questions rather than settling them.

Two kinds of authority are especially visible in the collection. State authority appears in officials, kings, ministers, and administrative decisions. Cultural authority takes the form of teachers, priests, village deities, folk songs, and genealogies. In Each One's Water, a sage teaches a king to exercise judgement; A Felicitation Volume criticizes the hollow prestige of political office; in The Rare Satyanarayan Worship a priest himself acknowledges the limitations of external ritual; and in Beniram a community creates the figure of a guardian deity. These different forms take the collection beyond entertainment alone.

10. Additional Questions for Research and Verification

The original footnotes preserve useful information about prior publication: 2002 is mentioned for Shastra-Chinta, 2003 for Faisla and Sapanak Dak, and journal publication in 2008 for the folkloric tales. Accordingly, the 2010 collection is not simply eleven new works written in a single year; it also gathers previously published pieces. The original periodical issues could be consulted to confirm pagination, textual variants, and first-publication dates. The present review does not invent unspecified variants in their absence. [Original pp. 40, 49, 54, 69, 76]

Two specific independent bibliographical details bear on the wider subject. Videha's digital book list records Katha-Lokkatha (2010) under Dr Yoganand Jha's name. The Sahitya Akademi's Maithili book list identifies Yoganand Jha as compiler and editor of Mithilak Lokkatha Sanchay, first published in 2017. The latter is bibliographic evidence of subsequent work on folktales. Because the text of that 2017 book has not been collated, the present study makes no definite claim that the two books contain identical tales or share particular textual readings.

A third external record appears in Japan's CiNii library catalogue: Maithili Katha-Sarita, edited by Madaneshwar Mishra and Yoganand Jha, is listed with a publication year of 1983. This limited verification connects Yoganand Jha with an earlier publication in the editorial culture of short fiction. It does not establish the origin of every literary feature of Stories and Folktales, or any specific equivalence of content with the 1983 collection. External evidence has been used only to this extent.

11. Conclusion: Achievements, Limitations, and Place in Maithili Short Fiction

The collection's principal achievement is not variety of subject alone but the bringing together of three ways in which literature lives: the writer's original concerns about present realities, an exchange of values through miniature

narratives translated from other languages, and stories preserved in the memories of folk communities. A journey beginning in national anxiety and reflection on scripture passes through Raghavji's official dilemma and Sukhlal's fear for his land, then through common water, self-respect, truthful conduct, and a critique of public honour. It ends in the worlds of food, solidarity among seven sisters, and Beniram's popular divinity. Through this sequence the book makes individuals, institutions, and communities alike the subjects of literature.

The artistic achievement is not uniform. In the original stories, ideas sometimes outweigh characters; in the miniatures, moral endings can make the narratives excessively direct; in the folk tales, the author's introductory and concluding explanations guide meanings that oral tradition might leave more open. Nevertheless, these differences aid our understanding of the book's form. The author generally takes a moral position, yet the text preserves tensions that invite renewed reading: security versus nonviolence, justice versus family, land versus records, labour versus consumption, and belief versus historical evidence.

For students of Maithili literature the book should not be reduced to the count of 'eleven stories'. Its lengthy introduction and foreword preserve the memory of literary gatherings and local writers; the footnotes reveal a chronology of the periodical world; the translated section documents linguistic exchange; the folkloric narratives provide material for studying communal ethics and belief; and the genealogical appendix partially records the memory of local descent. The literary and cultural value of the volume is evident in this multilayered character.

A proper critical judgement of the collection is neither unqualified glorification nor general dismissal on account of its moral tone. The conclusion supported by the sources is that it offers a meeting point in Maithili between modern social narration, the translation of ethical miniature stories, and the preservation of folk narrative. Its best use combines three tasks: reading the stories, preserving their original texts through responsible editing, and independently verifying the claims of folklore and history through research.

CHAPTER 10 / 2011

Sitavataran: The Descent of Sita

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

2. Introduction to the Book and Verified Publication Facts

Item	Publication details
Title	Sitavataran (a narrative poem)
Original poet	Kapildev Thakur “Snehalata”

Item	Publication details
Compilation and editing	Dr Yoganand Jha
First edition	2011
Publisher	Lok Kala Sanskriti Sansthan, Videhanagar, Darori, via Karua Hajparwa, Samastipur District, Bihar
Printed price	50 rupees
Original printed evidence	Title page, publication details, and editorial introduction: opening pages, especially printed pp. 3–4

The title page identifies the work as a prabandha-kavya, while the English description calls it 'Narrative Poetry'. It assigns separate credits to the author and the editor. This distinction must be preserved, because the editor himself states that the original work available to him was untitled and that he supplied the name Sitavataran. The 2011 edition, therefore, is not an unchanged facsimile publication of Snehalata's manuscript in its original form; it is a literary text reaching readers through editorial intervention.

As external corroboration, Videha's book list records 'Kapildev Thakur 'Snehalata', Sitavataran (edited), 2011' under Dr Yoganand Jha's name. This helps establish bibliographic identity, but the outside listing does not independently verify metre, textual accuracy, or the sequence of episodes.

3. The Historical Perspective of the Editor's Introduction and Its Critical Examination (pp. 3–4)

In his introduction, Dr Yoganand Jha describes Snehalata as a devotional poet of the Ramashrayi Rasik tradition from Darori village, in Mithila's Samastipur district, and gives his lifespan as 1909–1993. He attempts to place Snehalata against the background of Mithila's devotion to Rama, the song tradition surrounding the marriage of Sita and Rama, the saintly lineages, and lyric literature. The critical significance is that the poet's identity is not confined to one account of Sita's birth; it is situated within a wider world of devotional song and folk observances.

According to the introduction, Snehalata composed wedding lyrics, supplicatory lyrics, swing songs, chautavani, Shiva songs, and songs for life-cycle ceremonies throughout his life. The appendix corroborates the range of genres represented in this description by including praise of Mithila, invocation of Maithili or Sita, Krishna's divine play, and Maheshvani. Introduction and collected material thus illuminate one another. Yet this edition does not supply a complete record of the dates of composition and first publication of individual songs. The broad literary-historical assertions of the introduction are therefore treated here as the editor's statements rather than independently established findings.

The introduction reports the discovery of a narrative poem said to have remained 'unread and unexamined' until then. This statement belongs to the editor's introduction, written in December 2010; it cannot prove the absence of all subsequent academic study up to the present. Likewise, praise on an 'all-India' scale expresses the editor's critical admiration. It can become the conclusion of a separate study only after examining textual evidence in comparison with other contemporary works.

4. A Poetic Form Created through Editing: The Central Question of This Edition (p. 4)

The introduction makes its most consequential admission on p. 4: the available narrative poem 'had no title', and the editor named it Sitavataran in view of the episode of Sita's birth. He further writes that, in keeping with 'the requirements of the subject', he inserted some of Snehalata's independent lyrics at various places to clarify its narrative character. This establishes two distinct historical acts: assigning a title and incorporating songs. Neither diminishes the poet's creative contribution, but the poet's original organization and the editor's final arrangement cannot reasonably be treated as one and the same thing.

The positive aspect of this editorial experiment is that dispersed devotional lyrics and narrative passages are brought together, allowing readers to enter the wider emotional world of Mithila. A text that might have remained inaccessible perhaps acquired an organized form for reading. On the other hand, no page-by-page account identifies which songs originally belonged to the narrative, which were added later, which episodes were moved, or which manuscript served as the base text. Without such an account, the limits between the original poet's composition and the editor's structuring intervention cannot be determined. This is a significant deficiency in textual editing, especially because the edition explicitly acknowledges incorporating additional material.

Consequently, its standing as a prabandha-kavya should be assessed at two levels. Where there is a clear sequence of events and causal connections—Janaka's sacrifice, Sita's emergence from the earth, and the celebrations—the work displays the potential for an integrated narrative poem. Where the songs of Rama's birth or Shiva and Gauri stand as independent pieces for singing, there is not the uninterrupted flow of a formally divided epic, but a devotional narrative arranged with songs. This may be seen as a weakness or as an originality associated with Mithila's folk-theatrical traditions. Before reaching a decisive judgement, the limits of the editor's intervention must be established.

5. Dedication, Purpose of Composition, and the Poet's Spiritual Self-Presentation (pp. 5, 7, 9–10)

The complete handwritten passage in the available copy is not legible with certainty, and it has therefore not been treated as a source from which to

reproduce an authenticated verbatim quotation. Its presence in print nevertheless offers material evidence of a relationship between the editor and the devotional circle.

The 'Words of Dedication' (p. 7) connect the volume to devotees of Sita and Rama and to the imaginative world of the Ramcharitmanas. Its language is reverential; the purpose of publication and the inner voice of the poetry meet here. The page suggests that the book is intended not only for the literary enjoyment of modern readers but also for recitation, singing, worship, congregational kirtan, and communal devotional practice.

The 'Purpose of Composition' (pp. 9–10) foregrounds Darori and Mithila, affection for the marriage of Sita and Rama, imaginings of their childhood forms, pure feeling, the devotional community, and recollection of the name 'Lalit Lata'. The poet presents himself as a humble servant, not as a historian speaking with absolute certainty. Four elements thus underlie the act of poetic composition: a locally sacred geography, loving devotion to the worshipped couple, the community's tradition of congregational singing, and the insistence upon remembering the divine name. Its beauty cannot adequately be judged by plot alone.

6. Invocation of Saraswati and the Auspicious Opening: From Humility to Poetry (pp. 11–12)

On p. 11 the poetic text begins with 'Shri Ganeshaya Namah' and a 'Saraswati Vandana'. A direct appeal such as 'Mother Saraswati, when will you remove my ignorance?' reveals the poet's humility before learning. In the sentiment 'I am your child, Mother', the bond between deity and devotee becomes that of giver of knowledge and dependent child. While connected to the classical tradition of auspicious invocations, the actual language is domestic and reminiscent of folk song.

The prayer for 'a little corner of compassion' and the removal of ignorance creates images centred on tenderness. Knowledge is not conceived as an external rank or privilege but as a human capacity received through grace. Structurally this is a threshold: a wider scene of religious crisis follows it. The poet first acknowledges his limitations and then imagines the moral authority to narrate the restoration of dharma, divine descent, and the royal household.

7. Opening Narrative: Crisis of Dharma, Divine Descent, and Mithila's Need (pp. 12–14)

Pages 12–14 speak of unrighteousness, violence, fear, distress among the people, ruined peace, and the desire for dharma to be restored. Dharma is not merely private worship here; it appears as a value capable of dispelling social disorder. At the start, the conditions for the impending incarnation are created: society is out of balance, the earth and its people are in danger, and divine power may therefore descend into the human world. In this structure Sita's emergence is not an isolated miracle but a collective necessity.

The poet interweaves Mithila's marriage traditions with the birth of Rama. A prophetic sentiment resembling 'For the wedding in Mithila, we shall go and travel together' appears on p. 14. Narrative time and the devotee's present experience are closely joined: the ancient event of incarnation returns again and again in the present of communal singing. It is more appropriate to read this conjunction of times as an organization of devotional feeling than as a linear statement of historical dates.

The opening verses combine Sanskrit-based religious diction with familiar verbs, addresses, entreaties, and patterns of folk metre. 'Adharma', 'avatar', and 'dharma's banner' occur in lines whose sound invites communal performance. More than displays of intellectual ornament, the poet's language privileges the shared carrying of emotion. At places, awkward syntax and changing metrical regularity also appear. To call them all defects, or all deliberate feats of technique, would exceed the available evidence.

8. 'Sohar for Rama's Birth': A Poetic Transformation of a Life-Cycle Song (pp. 15–21)

The heading 'Ramjanma Sohar' and a series of numbered verses begin on p. 15 and continue to p. 21. Ayodhya's palace, Dasharatha's family, queens, glad news, musical instruments, gifts, donations, and the joy of a community of women make up the principal scenes. A mythological birth celebration is transformed into a locally recognizable ceremonial song. The word sohar denotes both a literary-singing genre and a social rite; it places the lyrics within the auditory world of courtyards, congratulations, women's collective voices, and auspicious occasions.

This section does not merely praise a divine incarnation. Gold, gifts to the household, clothing, instruments, and donations express the material abundance of the birth festival. The grandeur of royalty and practices familiar from popular life appear side by side. As news of the birth spreads from kin to the city, the narrative voice becomes collective rather than merely personal. The main literary effect is that Rama, while divine, is also an infant, a son, and the centre of family delight.

The particular interest of the verses on pp. 18–21 lies in the emotional difference between those who recognize Rama's divine nature and those who perceive his earthly child-form. Scattered gems, laughing queens, and singing groups are not mere exaggeration; they are a mode of manifesting devotional rasa. The inclusion of women's voices locates the song in a social ritual framework, although its concentration upon the royal couple leaves the labour and inequalities of ordinary families almost invisible. Modern criticism should acknowledge that limitation.

The place of an extended sohar for Rama's birth within a work titled Sitavataran raises a special critical question. Before Sita descends, readers encounter the worshipped couple through an extended account of Rama's birth. Yet, given the introduction's acknowledgement of inserted songs, the original position of this section cannot be assumed. Its effect in the published

poetic arrangement may be discussed; its precise state in the manuscript may not.

9. Janaka's Longing, Narada's Counsel, and the Turn to Shiva Worship (pp. 21–22)

After the account of Rama's birth, the story advances towards King Janaka's family. Pages 21–22 refer to his longing for a daughter, the gathering at his court, and advice offered by sages. Janaka asks about refuge and spiritual means after receiving assurances associated with the incarnations of Vishnu and the great divine power. Narada, Shiva, ascetic practice, and sacrificial worship become mechanisms of transition in the plot.

This transition is distinctive because Sita's birth is not represented as a merely biological continuation of a dynasty. It is an event combining divine intention, the crisis of dharma, and the welfare of the people. The land of Mithila is no mere setting; it becomes the earth from which the next incarnation is to emerge. The importance of a daughter lies at the centre of Janaka's longing. In comparison with the customary patriarchal desire for a son, the sacred hope for a daughter's birth creates a cultural reversal.

10. 'Shaiva Padavali': Shiva and Gauri in Domestic Speech and Playful Opposition (pp. 22–29)

A separate section entitled 'Shaiva Padavali' begins on p. 22. Gauri's familiar speech is heard in its first lyric. Words suggesting that 'Bambhola would keep me as a servant, Gauri', together with drinking bhang, a hut, and attendance, turn Shiva from a distant celestial deity into a character in Mithila's domestic teasing and joking. The coexistence of grandeur and humour in Shiva devotion is demonstrable from the text; it would therefore be wrong simply to label these poems 'hymns to Shiva' and stop there.

The dialogic songs on pp. 23–25 portray marriage, the bride's family, the bridegroom's unusual appearance, Gauri's apprehension, the affairs of the household, bhang, and affectionate quarrelling. Repeated forms of address such as 'He Dani' heighten the possibility of a responsive relation between performer and listeners. The poetic voice brings the universe-protecting Mahadeva into the jesting world of village weddings. This is not simply irony between an 'exalted' mythic image and 'lowly' domestic conduct: it is the inclusive poetic movement of popular devotion.

On pp. 26–29, Gauri's displeasure, Shiva's assent, the intimacy of the family, and amorous reconciliation change from song to song. Direct speech, short line breaks, and rapid emotional shifts suggest that the pieces retain the traits of separate singable compositions even when placed together in the text. One purpose of the Shiva songs within the narrative is to prepare Janaka's observances, Mahadeva's goodwill, and Sita's advent. Another may be to preserve specimens of Snehalata's Shaiva lyrics in the collection. Both readings are possible, but the original editorial ordering has not been independently established.

The strength of the songs is their plurality of voices. No single omniscient narrator recounts the mythology: Gauri, Dani, the bridegroom's people, women, and devotees speak in changing registers. Before imposing rigid metrical counts, the critic should consider the refrain, rhythmic fragments, and repetitions of folk performance. Neither original musical notation nor melodies are available, and this review therefore makes no claim to a particular raga or tala.

11. Janaka's Sacrifice, Drought, and Preparations for the Earth-Born Daughter (pp. 30–32)

After the Shiva songs, the narrative voice returns unmistakably on p. 30, describing Janaka's sacrifice, counsel from the sages, preparation of the sacrificial ground, and disturbance of the earth's balance. An imperative such as 'Now go and perform the sacrifice, O Janaka' propels the story into its next stage. The sacrifice is not merely a depiction of ritual: it symbolizes a communal religious response to the people's suffering.

Page 31 refers to the absence of rainfall and society's distress, the hoped-for completion of the sacrifice, and the date of Panchami. Mithila's land, its sacred river, and seasonal time together establish a geographical and temporal framework for Sita's birth. Janaka is presented both as a king concerned for his afflicted land and as a father awaiting the fulfilment of divine purpose.

On p. 32, Janaka ploughing the earth, the longing expressed in 'the daughter of my heart', the earth's womb, and the emergence of a girl are united within an image of nature. Field, plough, furrow, golden radiance, and an infant's cry bring Sita's birth into the centre of agrarian popular life rather than a palace. Here the title Sitavataran takes on its most concrete meaning: the incarnation is of supreme divine power, the medium is Mithila's earth, and the first witness is King Janaka.

12. Sita's Appearance, Daughterly Affection, and Public Rejoicing (pp. 32–35)

Pages 32–33 picture the golden plough, the earth, the radiant girl, and news spreading through the city. The absence of a daughter that had troubled Janaka turns into happiness at the appearance of the earth-born child. A lyric announcement on p. 34—'Mithila's earth has become blessed: Janaki is born'—compresses this transformation into a single sentiment. It joins land, domestic good fortune, the community's identity in Mithila, and the birth of a daughter in one expression.

On p. 33, the child's radiance, the glow of her face, comparisons with moon and sun, and everyone's acclamation create divine beauty. The similes are numerous, yet they also represent an attempt to understand the force of a divine body through popular perception. Janaka is happy with Sunayana at the birth of their daughter; this shared parental joy distinguishes the scene from the mere depiction of a royal miracle.

On pp. 34–35, singing, a delighted city, auspicious glimpses, gifts, and celebrations return. The collective happiness that surrounded Rama's birth in Ayodhya finds its Mithila-centred counterpart in Sita's birth. This repetition is not merely narrative redundancy; it is a poetic means of giving equal emotional value to the paired births of Rama and Sita in two different cities. The editorial organization of the two sections is not, however, separately explained. We cannot establish whether their correspondence was deliberately planned by the poet or arose from the editor's selection.

A vital caution is required in evaluating the birth of a daughter. The poet praises Sita as the ideal divine girl; this is not a manifesto proclaiming equal social rights for every girl. Nevertheless, the royal family's desire for a daughter and Mithila's public celebration create an emotional world in which a girl's birth is auspicious, desired, and a cause of communal pride. That much the literary evidence demonstrates; it does not furnish a survey of gender relations throughout historical Mithila.

13. Structure: The Tension between Continuous Narrative and Independent Songs

The text available to us has a principal sequence: invocation; the crisis of dharma and contemplation of incarnation; the sohar of Rama's birth; Janaka's longing for a daughter; Shiva worship and Shaiva lyrics; Janaka's sacrifice; Sita's emergence from the earth; and the city's celebration. This clearly marked progression allows the work to be read as a narrative. Yet the numbered verses, refrains, spoken voices, and suggestions of singing and dancing in the Ramjanma Sohar and Shaiva Padavali also make them seem like independent poetic units.

If one expects an extended traditional narrative poem always to maintain one metre, one narrator, formally divided cantos, or continuous character development, this work reveals a different nature. It is an account of divine characters constructed with the assistance of folk songs, deriving more creative energy from an emotional world than from tightly joined incidents. The publisher's description 'prabandha-kavya' is a documented fact; whether the work fully realizes that artistic form remains a critical question.

When read in the imagined setting of collective song, many breaks may be experienced as changes of scene in folk theatre. On the written page, however, signals marking the return to the narrative are limited, and the pace of scenes changes abruptly. Justice to the poetry requires acknowledging both sides: the vitality of a folk-based form and the weakness of transitions in the edited text.

14. Poetic Language: Devotional Diction, Colloquial Maithili, and Mixed Song Vocabulary

The language brings together religious words derived from Sanskrit, such as 'avatar', 'mahashakti', 'yajna', and 'Saraswati'; familiar terms of Mithila's popular life, such as 'sohar', 'baba', 'dani', 'hajir', 'bhang', and 'Gauri'; and everyday verbs. Such coexistence does not automatically indicate linguistic

carelessness. The audience for devotional poetry moves between learned readers and folk performers. The sweetness of particles and verbal forms such as 'he', 're', 'nahi', 'chhathi', and 'gabathi' helps establish its audible quality.

The poet's identifying signature, or bhanita, varies within the book, taking forms such as 'Snehalata' and 'Latika Saneh'. Such differences do not necessarily invalidate common authorship; devotional poetry has different conventions for poetic signatures, affectionate names, and concluding self-reference. At the same time, normalizing all variants without checking the printed pages would risk corrupting the text. An essential distinction must be made between typographical mistakes requiring correction and the phonetic or vernacular diversity of the original songs.

In some verses, word order departs from standard prose grammar; elsewhere, Sanskrit compounds weigh down the musical rhythm, while repetitions drawn from folk practice simplify meaning. Criticism needs to ask which irregularities belong to the poet's style, which to choices in editing, and which to printing errors. Without a base manuscript, definitive textual emendations have not been proposed.

15. The Interplay of Rasas: Service, Parental Love, Humour, and Public Welfare

Devotion to Rama and Sita is the prevailing emotion, yet its expression is far from monotonous. The opening invocation is humble supplication, Rama's birth evokes parental tenderness and joy, the Shiva–Gauri episodes convey affectionate humour, Janaka's sacrifice mingles sorrow and hope, and Sita's descent brings wonder and collective rejoicing. This movement between emotions turns the lyrical arrangement into a kind of journey through feeling.

In particular, Shiva's association with bhang and Gauri's oblique domestic perspective give popular devotion a playful voice. This shows that Snehalata's faith is not confined to restrained praise of divinities: he can create a family-like divine world whose members talk, laugh, sulk, and reconcile. In contrast, the radiance, light, and acclaim of Sita's birth produce wonder. To subsume this diversity under 'erotic sentiment' or 'devotion' alone would diminish the text's multiplicity.

16. A Cultural Reading of Mithila's Geography, Agriculture, and Rites

References to Darori, Videhanagar, Mithila, Janaka, the plough, sacrificial ground, river, and earth create an intimate geography. The cry 'Mithila's earth is blessed' is not a geographical label alone; it gives the land an emotional body. In the tale of a daughter emerging from the earth, implements of agriculture—the plough, the field, and tilling—acquire religious significance.

The instruments of the sohar, words of congratulation, playful exchanges between bride and bridegroom, marriage talk, and suggestions of communal

singing by women are important as written traces of Mithila's ceremonial world. But they are literary images. They cannot establish the entire anthropological reality of present practice in a specific village, its caste distribution, or women's actual ritual roles. Poetry centred on rasa offers cultural evidence, not a social census.

17. Narrative Perspective and Women's Voices: Sita, Sunayana, Gauri, and the Singing Community

Sita is the most venerated figure in the volume; her emergence is described through the sentiments of land and family. Her own direct speech, however, is very limited on the pages available, because the narrative ends with celebrations of her birth. It would be unsupported to invent here her later self-determination, mature womanhood, or subsequent moral vocation. The central subject concerning women is the longing for her appearance, not her entire life story.

By contrast, Gauri speaks with relative force in the Shiva songs. She herself raises questions about marriage, dress, food, outward appearance, quarrels, reconciliation, and domestic life. This difference is critically interesting: Sita, the great goddess, is portrayed as a divine image, while Gauri takes the form of a familiar, speaking woman. Each fulfils its literary purpose in context, yet the inequality of their voices is evident in the text.

18. The Appendix and the Poet's Wider Creative World (pp. 36–48)

The heading 'Appendix: Some Distinctive Songs by Snehalata' is printed on p. 36. It establishes that the editor identifies this section as separate from the principal narrative poem. The lyrics must not be treated in criticism as the next natural cantos of Sita's birth story. They are evidence of the poet's varied interests, and in publication terms they extend the reader's introduction to him.

18.1 'Praise of Mithila' (p. 36)

'Mithila Mahima' presents Mithila as a beloved land of nature, culture, tradition, and the child Rama. Beginning with 'in the immortal lap of the earth', the hymn forms an emotional picture of Mithila's cultural place in the world. Sacred geography becomes pride in one's native land. In the main poem Janaka's earth serves as a symbol; in the appendix the land itself becomes the subject of praise.

18.2 'Invocation of Maithili' and 'Parati' (pp. 37, 47–48)

In 'Maithili Vandana', Queen Sita is made the centre of compassion, righteousness, and surrender; the worship of the central female figure comes in the devotee's own first-person voice. The term 'Maithili' here has an immediately apparent association with the goddess and should not automatically be equated with the name of the language. The 'Parati' on p. 48 contains a call to awaken at dawn. The day's recurring cycle and the repetition

of devotional observance illuminate the occasion for performing such folk songs.

18.3 'Supplication' and 'Invocation of Rama' (p. 38)

The lines of 'Vinay' chiefly express taking refuge in God, remorse, and the wish for forgiveness. Readers can discern the bond between the poet's devotional sensibility and moral self-examination. 'Ram Vandana' then praises the Lord's qualities and his compassion towards the humble. Compared with the collective rejoicing in the main narrative, these two songs belong more to private spiritual practice. The strength of the supplicatory song lies not merely in seeing the self as helpless but in awakening the possibility of refuge.

18.4 'Krishna's Play at the Water-Ghat' (pp. 39–43)

'Shri Krishna's Panghat Lila' brings together the gopis, Yamuna, the place for drawing water, water itself, Krishna's playful obstruction of passage, laughter, teasing, and reproach. With Krishna as its hero, the movement of narration shifts from Mithila's Rama worship towards the nimble folk sweetness of Vrindavan. This is not merely a specimen of a different religious allegiance: domestic voices, playful rituals, and teasing resistance create a distinct lyric form through the dialogues of female characters. The piece ends on p. 43, where the next Maheshvani begins.

18.5 'Maheshvani' (pp. 43–47)

In 'Maheshvani', Shiva's unusual appearance, Gauri's domestic complaints, Narada, ashes, ghosts, and divinity combine in amusing, seemingly incongruous ways. Its subject is close to that of the Shaiva Padavali in the main section, but no firm manuscript evidence permits us to call them two versions of the same work or separate parts of an original sequence. The available evidence allows only the conclusion that humour and worship do not obstruct one another in the poet's Shaiva folk songs.

18.6 'Warning' and 'Snehalata's Last Unfinished Composition' (p. 48)

The last surviving printed page presents, under the heading 'Warning', a message concerning life's transience, attachment, and awakening. It also bears a heading, 'Snehalata's Last Unfinished Composition'. The word 'unfinished' is itself part of the editorial presentation; the fragment must not be forced into a complete lyric, nor may a missing ending be fabricated. The adjective 'last' does not, on the strength of a heading alone, establish that this was historically the very last poem Snehalata wrote. It establishes the categorization used in this edition.

19. Why the Distinction between Appendix and Main Narrative Matters

The appendix expands our understanding of Snehalata's devotional world: Rama, Sita, Krishna, Shiva, Mithila, supplication, and warning. It is therefore useful comparative material for literary criticism. It cannot, however, change

the assessment of the size and narrative distribution of Sitavataran itself, because the editor clearly distinguishes those songs from the main work. It would be factually incorrect to describe all forty-eight printed pages as pages of one continuous narrative of Sita's birth.

A further important point is that, although Snehalata belonged to a Ramashrayi Rasik tradition, he wrote with ease on Shiva and Krishna as well. This coexistence suggests the possibility of an inclusive form of devotion. There is no adequate evidence here, however, for reconstructing a historical change of sect, a fixed lineage of gurus, or a systematic list of doctrinal influences. It is more faithful to the evidence to remain with the demonstrable diversity of his poetry.

20. Printing and Textual Editing: Responsibility towards the Reader

On p. 4 the editor asks forgiveness for possible errors arising in collection, editing, and printing. Acknowledging errors is not an invitation to alter the poet's text without restraint. On the contrary, it makes it more necessary for scholarship to compare the available edition with the original manuscript. Modernization without preserving the original refrain, line division, poetic signature, any details of melody or rhythm, and the form of the metre would be dangerous.

In the course of this study, handwriting on p. 5 and the poor quality of a few reproduced portions prevent absolutely certain readings of every letter. This review therefore does not invent line-by-line etymologies, disputes of authorship, or grammatical theories based on unclear words. The next stage of responsible textual editing requires access to the original manuscript, a line-by-line record of variants, and comparison with other published works by the poet.

21. Evaluation: Achievements and Limitations on Four Interconnected Criteria

21.1 Thematic Achievement

The poet's most important achievement is to connect Sita's emergence from the earth with Mithila's everyday life, the agrarian image of the plough, and communal joy at a daughter's birth. She is divine power, but a father's longing, a mother's happiness, and the city's singing make her an intimate child of the household. The union of familiarization and glorification is central to this poetry.

21.2 Achievement of Form

Snehalata's language is suited to being heard. Refrains, direct address, repetition, the rhythmic pulse of the sohar, humorous conversation, and words from folk observances combine to create poetry capable of performance. The energy of Shaiva Padavali and Ramjanma Sohar draws the reader beyond the printed page towards imagined singing. Their achievement is to preserve a predominantly auditory experience in written verse.

21.3 Narrative Limitation

Transitions between the central story and independent lyrics are often abrupt. Despite the title Sitavataran, the extensive treatment of Rama's birth and Shiva–Gauri episodes creates uneven proportions for a reader seeking a closely concentrated story. Yet it would be unfair to assign all responsibility for this to the original poet, for the editor acknowledges inserting independent lyrics. The precise critical statement is that 'the transitions are insufficiently clear in the edited edition available to us'.

21.4 Research Value and Editorial Limitation

The volume preserves in print poetic material in danger of being lost and introduces Snehalata's diverse lyric traditions. It does not, however, provide photographic plates of the original manuscript, a complete collation of variants, a table recording where each added song was placed, dates of song collection, or a detailed account of metre and sound. This does not make the editor's contribution unimportant; it establishes the need for a future authoritative critical edition.

22. Testing against Independent External Sources: What Is and Is Not Confirmed

Videha's book list mentions the edited volume published in 2011. The library list of Maithil Manch records a book titled Vaidehi Vivah Sankirtan under Kapildev Thakur 'Snehalata'. Taken together, these establish the public existence of a volume edited in 2011 and a body of writing centred on Rama and Sita. No line-by-line collation with Vaidehi Vivah Sankirtan has been undertaken here; guessing how many compositions are identical or different would therefore be unwarranted.

A 2021 news item in Maithil Manch refers to a proposed documentary on Snehalata and his connection with Darori village. Such a report can be viewed as a contemporary indication of efforts to preserve the poet's memory. It does not establish that the film was completed or released, or that its research claims were verified. The book's own introduction remains the principal biographical source for this study; external sources provide supporting context only.

Printed location	Contents
Cover–printed p. 4	Cover, title, publication details, and editorial introduction
Printed pp. 5–10	Facsimile of handwritten message, words of dedication, and “Purpose of Composition”
Printed pp. 11–14	Invocation of Ganesha, invocation of Saraswati, crisis of dharma, and introduction to incarnation
Printed pp. 15–21	“Ramjanma Sohar”: numbered songs and festivities in Ayodhya

Printed location	Contents
Printed pp. 22–29	Transition to Janaka's desire and "Shaiva Padavali": lyrics on Shiva and Gauri
Printed pp. 30–35	Janaka's sacrifice, birth of the earth-born girl, Sunayana, and Mithila's celebration
Printed pp. 36–38	Appendix: Mithila Mahima, Maithili Vandana, opening of Parati, Vinay, and Ram Vandana
Printed pp. 39–43	Appendix: Krishna's Panghat Lila
Printed pp. 43–47	Appendix: Maheshvani and lyrics concerning Shiva and Gauri
Printed p. 48	Parati/Warning and "Snehalata's Last Unfinished Composition"

24. Consolidated Critical Conclusion

Sitavataran is an edited publication in which Kapildev Thakur 'Snehalata's' capacity for devotional narrative, a sensibility centred on Rama and Sita, and the living sound of Maithili folk song converge. Its central scene is the earth-born appearance of Sita. The story moves from a crisis of dharma through Janaka's longing for a daughter, a sacrifice, the womb of the earth, and a city's celebration. Mithila's agrarian culture, affection for a daughter's birth, and a family's intimacy with divinity give this scene its force.

The poetic organization must be seen clearly. It is not one uninterrupted canto-like narrative, but an edited narrative text sustained by folk singing. The relative independence of the sohar for Rama's birth and the Shaiva songs, the distinct appendix devoted to Krishna and Shiva, and the varying poetic signatures are valuable historical material. Its achievement is not conformity to a 'pure' epic model but the written preservation of popular sound and devotional experience.

The editorial conclusion is equally clear. Dr Yoganand Jha's 2011 publication has significant value as a collection and preservation of texts, but his acknowledged acts of naming and incorporating lyrics require critics to distinguish the responsibilities of composer and editor. Without this distinction, final pronouncements on the metre, original sequence, poet's intentions, or structural merits and defects would violate the evidence. The edition is valuable partly because it reveals something of its own making.

Ultimately, the volume helps the study of modern Maithili literary history in two ways: it makes available a relatively little-known body of Rama devotion centred on Mithila, and it offers a rare opportunity to examine exchanges between congregational song, ceremonial folk genres, and written poetry. The most productive future research would compare this edition, on an evidentiary basis, with the original manuscript, Snehalata's other song collections, and living oral performance traditions—without replacing missing evidence with speculation.

CHAPTER II / 2013

Mangal-Prabhat: An Auspicious Morning

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

1. Introduction to the Book and Research Method

Mangal-Prabhat is a Maithili translation of Mahatma Gandhi's explanations of rules of life written for residents of his ashram. The English publication details on the opening pages make clear that Dr Yoganand Jha presented the material in Maithili on the basis of a Hindi translation. The title page, publication information, and permission letter establish that it appeared in 2013 from the Mithila Research Society, Darbhanga, with permission from the Navajivan Trust. Its study is therefore not merely a summary of Gandhian philosophy but a combined examination of ideas, translation, Maithili readership, and publication history. (Printed pp. 1–3, 13–14, 67–68)

The explanations of the ashram vows are not ordinary paragraphs of exhortation. The opening essay discusses the reason for the title Mangal-Prabhat, the decision to speak on one vow after Tuesday morning prayers, and the publication of the resulting reflections. Dates attached to the individual essays, from 22 July to 14 October 1930, demonstrate their serial composition. Reading them in this historical order reveals that Gandhi discusses each vow as a distinct subject while repeatedly connecting it to truth, nonviolence, and collective life. (Pp. 17–18; dates at the heads of the essays)

A second source is the English edition of From Yeravda Mandir available through Sevagram Ashram, together with original or institutional material concerning the ashram vows. The English book is used to compare the larger textual tradition of Gandhian thought and the ordering of chapters, not to certify the Maithili translation word for word. Without a line-by-line comparison with the intervening Hindi text, it would be improper to declare a particular Maithili rendering an 'error'.

2. Publishing Tradition, Preliminary Matter, and the Translator's Introduction

The book opens with a dedication, a blessing, an introductory statement about the importance of Gandhian literature, 'From the Translator', and Kaka Kalelkar's 'Submission'. These provide different points of entry for readers. On one side they emphasize Gandhi's ideals and the need for intellectual literature in Maithili; on another, the translator explains his aim of making Gandhi's original ideas available in the language. Kaka Kalelkar raises the question of linguistic circulation and expresses the wish that those ideas should reach India's multilingual public. (Pp. 5–15)

'From the Translator' (pp. 13–14) is particularly important. Here the translator explains his literary motivation and practical difficulties of

translation and publication: obtaining permission, arranging Maithili publication, and expanding readership. The book thereby becomes more than the importation of ideas; it represents a deliberate attempt to enlarge Maithili's resources for philosophical and ethical prose. Kaka Kalelkar's 'Submission' on p. 15 bears the date 6 June 1958. To mistake that date for the publication date of the Maithili volume in 2013 would be an error: it belongs to an earlier prefatory statement.

According to the publication details, the Hindi intermediary is attributed to Amritlal Thakordas Manavati. The probable chain of transmission is therefore 'Gandhi's original writing → Hindi translation → Maithili translation'. To call the Maithili a direct rendering of an English edition would contradict the evidence supplied by the book itself. The complete Hindi intermediary was not available among the primary materials examined here, however, so claims about subtle differences between translations are deliberately withheld.

3. Fifteen Principal Essays: Text, Argument, and Critical Assessment

3.1 Truth

Original text: printed pp. 19–21; essay dated 22 July 1930.

In the opening essay, truth extends beyond the virtue of speaking honestly to questions of existence and God. The text connects sat with being, presence, and the real existence of a thing; satya is contemplated as a name of God. The reasoning establishes an inseparable relation between Gandhi's ethical life and spirituality. The insistence is that human beings should seek a more encompassing truth through their practice of truthfulness in everyday affairs. The essay thus becomes the foundational text for the vows that follow.

Especially noteworthy is that truth is not restricted to speech. Thought, behaviour, and an honest endeavour within the mind are also part of it. The search requires self-scrutiny, the review of one's decisions, and efforts to overcome greed and fear. In this view truth is less an immovable pronouncement than a continuous method of moral self-examination. Spiritual idiom supplies its philosophical foundation, but contact with social action makes the idea active.

A critical question follows: how should private experience of truth be distinguished from public evidence? Without diminishing Gandhi's ethical search for truth, one must recognize that personal conviction does not automatically establish a historical or scientific fact. A commitment to truth in modern public life must be accompanied by documents, inquiry, and rational verification. The strength of this account is moral integrity, not a final verdict on every factual dispute.

3.2 Nonviolence

Original text: printed pp. 22–24; essay dated 29 July 1930.

The essay on ahimsa treats truth and nonviolence as two connected aspects of a single discipline. Complete apprehension of truth is difficult, it says, and therefore requires the discipline of love and nonviolent means. Nonviolence is not merely refraining from killing; it resists the inner forms of hatred, anger, jealousy, and revenge. It does not require abandoning opposition to oppression. Rather, its demanding condition is to oppose injustice without nurturing hatred for the person who commits it.

The example of a thief is important. Instead of simply classifying the offender as an enemy, it urges recognition of that person's remaining human possibilities. In contrast with a narrowly punitive culture, the example opens questions about the causes of wrongdoing, treatment, and possible reform. Nonviolence, in this sense, is not passive tolerance; it sets an ethical limit on the exercise of force. Its concerns extend to physical, verbal, and mental behaviour.

One caution is required in applying these ideas. Demanding 'love' or 'forgiveness' from a person who has suffered harm cannot justify denying that person's right to safety or justice. Oppression, domestic violence, and discrimination demand legal protection and substantive institutional resistance. Gandhi's rejection of retaliatory hatred may be valuable, but to turn it into silent acquiescence by the victim would diminish the idea's social force.

3.3 Brahmacharya

Original text: printed pp. 25–28; essay dated 5 August 1930.

The essay presents restraint as a discipline that supports all the other vows. Brahmacharya here is not simply outward sexual abstinence, but the regulation of mind, senses, attachment, and conduct. At the outset it asks how someone aspiring to truth, nonviolence, and self-surrender can justify uncontrolled desire and private indulgence. This question highlights the place of self-restraint within the shared life of the ashram.

An essential feature is the relation between personal discipline and the wider impulse to serve. Affection may, if reduced to an excessively narrow form of possessiveness, hinder a person's ability to work for others. For this reason the writer calls for the control of both body and mind. Discussion of food, sensory desires, and appetite provides a logical link with the next essay, 'Control of the Palate'.

Modern analysis should not impose brahmacharya as a single obligatory way of life on everyone. Consent, bodily autonomy, equality within marriage, and gender justice are essential aspects of dignity. The chapter must therefore be studied in the historical setting of ashram discipline. The positive meanings of restraint—responsibility, respect within relationships, and freedom from

possessiveness—must be considered separately from the possible limits of strict moral control over private lives.

3.4 Control of the Palate

Original text: printed pp. 29–32; essay dated 12 August 1930.

The title asvad does not deny the existence of pleasure in food; it cautions against making the pursuit of taste the principal goal of life. Food sustains the body, the writer explains, while eating only for the tongue's pleasure may obstruct self-control. The essay connects restraint of taste with brahmacharya: discipline over the tongue serves as practice in governing the senses. It argues against unnecessary overeating, craving for flavours, and enjoyment beyond genuine need.

The text compares eating according to need and usefulness with taking medicine. In this way Gandhi's ethics reaches into the body's ordinary daily activities. Someone may speak publicly of truth and nonviolence, but if unable to restrain personal consumption, the order of vows remains incomplete. This is the essay's central connection.

Contemporary analysis must take account of nutrition, age, physical work, health, and the cultural significance of meals. Mindfulness about taste and criticism of excess are useful; strict prohibition, however, must not be presented as a universal law of medicine. In a society living with malnutrition, moral commands to 'eat less' can be detached from material reality. The text argues for discrimination in consumption, not the glorification of hunger.

3.5 Non-Stealing

Original text: printed pp. 33–35; essay dated 19 August 1930.

The essay on asteya extends the notion of stealing far beyond the narrow act of taking something contrary to law. Taking unnecessary objects, misusing things meant for others, or accumulating more than one's needs may also approach theft in the ethical sense. Gandhi thus moves beyond the formal legal ownership of property to raise questions about necessity and just consumption.

The tension between 'need' and 'right' is a special feature of the chapter. Even an item legally purchased may, when used needlessly, put pressure on common resources. That argument remains pertinent to the contemporary scarcity of resources. Non-stealing is presented in relation to truth and nonviolence: mutual trust, nonviolent conduct, and limited consumption are mutually dependent.

This reasoning also has limits. What counts as 'necessary' varies with class, illness, disability, childhood, kinds of labour, and social circumstances. Ethical non-stealing must not become an instrument for harsh surveillance of the modest desires of the poor. It has greater significance when applied to waste, exploitation, and unequal access to resources among dominant social groups.

3.6 Non-Possession

Original text: printed pp. 36–38; essay dated 26 August 1930.

Aparigraha is the next logical step after non-stealing. The chapter urges people not to accumulate things beyond need, to reduce acquisitiveness, and to limit everyday consumption. In the writer's view, accumulated property cannot guarantee security or satisfaction. The fitting use of necessary things and the capacity to serve others are more meaningful measures of an ethical life.

The text poses a moving question: when innumerable people lack the basic means of life, why is excessive accumulation by those who are prosperous treated as normal? Through this question non-possession expands from religious asceticism into the debate about distributive justice. Giving up hoarding does not mean complete inactivity; the ideal is to retain the ability to meet legitimate needs and to employ the resources remaining for the service of society.

The value of non-possession becomes clearer when voluntary moral renunciation is distinguished from involuntary deprivation. It would be irrational to call the modest safety reserves of people struggling to survive 'greed'. The concept is relevant to unequal distribution, consumerism, and responsible public expenditure; to imagine poverty as sacred in itself would not be a just application of it.

3.7 Fearlessness

Original text: printed pp. 39–40; essay dated 2 September 1930.

The essay on abhaya treats inner fearlessness as a necessary precondition of truth and nonviolence. It identifies many external sources of fear: death, livelihood, reputation, family members, the state, and social persecution. If the fear of consequences breaks one's commitment to truth, the moral pledge cannot endure. Fearlessness is therefore not only a heroic emotion but the difficult capacity to make just decisions.

One important quality is the distinction between fearlessness and violent recklessness. Courage, self-surrender, the search for truth, and self-correction constitute a disciplined disposition. The preparation to withstand external harm and loyalty to one's conscience are presented as necessary to effective nonviolent resistance.

Fearlessness and blind acceptance of danger are not the same. When calling on vulnerable citizens, oppressed groups, or survivors of violence to be fearless, society must also provide real protection, shelter, and institutional support. The finest social meaning of abhaya is to change structures that generate fear. Blaming only the frightened individual obscures the responsibilities of the state and society.

3.8 The Removal of Untouchability

Original text: printed pp. 41–43; essay dated 9 September 1930.

This essay views untouchability as a religious and social distortion and demands its abolition. Its opening directly rejects the ideas of 'untouchability' and the 'untouchable' as incompatible with human equality. The author criticizes divisions established through food, touch, labour, and ordinary social contact. The strength of the essay is that it recognizes social injustice not as a mere lack of courtesy but as a deeply rooted defect in collective practice.

The religious reasoning challenges attempts to legitimize discrimination in the name of faith. Such a challenge was particularly important for readers who had come to accept exclusion on caste grounds as an unquestioned tradition. The removal of untouchability thus becomes a concrete social test of truth and nonviolence. A claim to love others has meaning only when their dignity and equality are honoured in practice.

A tension emerges, however, in a critical reading. The main text mounts a strong case against discrimination, whereas p. 66 of the appendix also comments on the varna system and ashram life. Read together, these sections suggest possible discomfort between the declared aim of eliminating caste exclusion and discussions retaining elements of the traditional varna order. By modern standards of equality, rejecting untouchability must also mean an unequivocal rejection of caste hierarchy, hereditary restrictions on work, and unequal social opportunities.

3.9 Bread Labour and Livelihood

Original text: printed pp. 44–46; essay dated 16 September 1930.

This chapter treats work and livelihood as interdependent moral responsibilities. It introduces the idea of 'bread labour': anyone who eats should, according to ability, also undertake productive physical work. The principle challenges both the employer's privilege and the labourer's humiliation. Work becomes a way of developing character and promoting social equality.

An important turn occurs when the right to food of those who do no physical work is questioned morally, even as the duty to care for the elderly, the incapacitated, and dependants is also recognized. The essential concern is to increase respect for the hands that produce the necessities of life and to lessen distinctions of high and low founded upon occupations. The writer establishes the dignity of work partly through the example of doing physical labour himself.

Applying the premise unchanged in today's economy is difficult, since care work, teaching, intellectual labour, technological services, and employment suited to people with disabilities take many forms. Yet the arguments for the dignity of labour, workers' rights, the relation of production to consumption, and mutual service remain substantial. Moral duty must never justify low

wages or exploitation. The dignity of labour demands fair pay and security as well.

3.10 Equal Regard for All Religions—I

Original text: printed pp. 47–49; essay dated 23 September 1930.

The first essay on sarva-dharma-samabhava examines the meaning and moral limits of 'tolerance'. It moves beyond mere tolerance towards an attitude of equal regard. The central demand is that one abandon the assumption that one's own religion is without error and that another is necessarily inferior. Human understanding is limited; hence the human interpretations of religion may be incomplete.

The essay's strength is self-criticism. Respect for others is not merely a strategy for social peace; it emerges from awareness of the limits of one's own knowledge. Commitment to a faith and humility about religious claims are not treated as mutually exclusive. To say that human formulations of religions are incomplete does not mean that faith is meaningless. It means that human interpretations do not possess a monopoly on final truth.

Critically, one must distinguish equal regard from substantive freedom of religion. The ideal becomes powerful when legal rights of worship, nonbelief, departure from religion, dissent, and conversion are protected. Sentimental goodwill alone is inadequate: equal citizenship for minorities and those with divergent beliefs is essential. It is productive to relate the essay's moral purpose to modern discussions of rights.

3.11 Equal Regard for All Religions—II

Original text: printed pp. 50–52; essay dated 30 September 1930.

The second essay puts the principle into the practice of multireligious prayer in the ashram. It mentions praise and scriptural recitation from different religious traditions. The author sees opportunities for fellow feeling, education, and mutual respect. The earlier theoretical demand now becomes a direct experiment in social life.

A distinctive point is the insistence upon listening to the language of other faiths while retaining one's own understanding of religious truth. The purpose of dialogue is not to defeat the other but to lessen narrowness within oneself. This conception of religious plurality does not demand undisputed uniformity; it seeks an atmosphere of mutual discipline and respect within a community.

A critical issue is how adequately voluntary participation, the right to disagree, and the place of nonreligious persons are protected in shared prayer. Speaking the religious languages of different communities together can create solidarity, but religious participation must not become compulsory if all citizens are to be respected. On these terms, the Gandhian proposal for reducing communal division can enter a constructive dialogue with democratic pluralism.

3.12 Humility

Original text: printed pp. 53–54; essay dated 7 October 1930.

The essay reflects on the difficulty of treating humility as a separate vow. Humility, it suggests, does not arise from a written pledge but from the gradual reduction of inward pride. It is therefore regarded as a quality running through all the vows. Someone who grows proud of keeping the truth and looks down upon others may lose the very spirit of that moral practice.

The spiritual element of the essay is closely connected to service. A person who understands the limits of the self moves away from boasting of personal achievements and towards responsibility for the wider life of society. Humility in this sense is not servility, but cooperation without arrogance. The essay's figurative language makes the difficulty of self-cultivation easier to grasp.

Humility is particularly useful in present-day public debate, where argument too often degenerates into the veneration of personalities. Yet it would be harmful to turn the ideal into an order for disadvantaged groups to remain silent. Asking questions, resisting injustice, and asserting one's rights do not contradict humility. Proper humility limits the arrogance associated with power; it does not erase self-respect.

3.13 Swadeshi: A Preliminary Note

Original text: printed p. 55; numbered separately as item 13 in the contents.

In this short piece Gandhi explains that a fuller account of swadeshi may naturally involve political meanings, but his principal attention is upon its moral and religious dimension. It introduces the ensuing discussion of the vow of swadeshi. Although brief, its critical importance is considerable: if swadeshi is understood only as a programme for boycotting foreign goods, half its meaning is lost.

The passage also clarifies the intended audience. It lays the ground for linking swadeshi with service to those nearby, self-discipline, and responsibility. That is why assigning this brief note a separate place in the contents is meaningful. Absorbing it without comment into the following 'Swadeshi Vow' would obscure the book's editorial organization.

The appropriate method of reading the note is to distinguish political nationalism, economic localism, and ethical responsibility to those close to us. This distinction clarifies the assessment of the merits and problems of the writer's treatment of swadeshi.

3.14 The Swadeshi Vow

Original text: printed pp. 56–59.

Swadeshi is understood here as a primary responsibility towards one's neighbours and nearby communities. The writer argues that a lofty intention to serve distant people may leave genuine obligations unfulfilled if one's immediate neighbours are neglected. Service beginning in local relationships

can ultimately reach the wider human family. Swadeshi thus appears not as a geographical prison but as a progressively widening circle of responsibility.

An important feature of the essay is the meeting of religious, social, and economic concerns. Being attentive to a neighbour's labour, products, and difficulties is part of swadeshi, but it must not become hatred towards people of another country or religion. By joining swadeshi to service and reciprocity, the writer distinguishes it from obstinate exclusion. Respect for local production, language, and cultural foundations can follow from this wider ethical impulse; these are potential modern applications, not a directly enumerated policy programme in the original text.

Contemporary assessment needs a balance between swadeshi and global interdependence. Medicines, science, education, trade, and assistance to migrant communities sometimes rely on international networks. Supporting local economies, environmental responsibility, and trade free of exploitation matters greatly, but the moral worth of a product or person cannot be judged solely by place of origin. The most fertile application of Gandhi's ethic of nearby service is to connect local responsibility with universal human dignity.

3.15 The Necessity of Vows

Original text: printed pp. 60–62; essay dated 14 October 1930.

The final principal essay examines the foundations of the entire book. It raises objections to vows: why is following a rule not enough, and why should a vow remain strict when conditions are difficult? The reply is that goodwill alone is insufficient; ethical decisions require firmness of resolve. A vow thereby becomes a public declaration of long-term discipline rather than a passing emotion.

The essay criticizes the uncertainty of saying 'as far as possible'. A vow is not cleverness in finding exceptions; it gives the strength to stand before temptation. The example of giving up alcohol, the comparison with the sun's predictable movement, and questions about keeping one's word illuminate the relation between principle and character. The essay brings the argument full circle to the opening discussion of truth.

In critical terms, resolve must be distinguished from rigidity. Decisions should be revised when new evidence reveals error or shows that other people are being harmed. The available English text from 1932 likewise recognizes that a vow later demonstrated to be wrong may need to be abandoned, although the Maithili essay emphasizes firm determination. Continually testing strict vows against judgement, medical exceptions, and just outcomes offers a prudent contemporary reading.

4. Independent Assessment of the Appendix: Eleven Ashram Vows

Printed pp. 63–66 contain an appendix with brief explanations of eleven ashram vows. The fifteen principal essays and eleven vows in the appendix must not be counted as the same set. In the principal section, the introduction

to swadeshi, the swadeshi vow, and two essays on equal regard for religions are counted separately, while humility and the need for vows also receive independent treatments. The appendix offers a concise practical scheme for life; the principal essays develop the vows' ethical justification.

The appendix follows this order: (1) truth, (2) nonviolence, (3) brahmacharya, (4) control of the palate, (5) non-stealing, (6) non-possession, (7) bread labour and livelihood, (8) swadeshi, (9) fearlessness, (10) the removal of untouchability, and (11) tolerance or the capacity to endure. (Printed pp. 63–66)

The appendix matters because philosophical concepts become a concrete list of practices. Non-stealing counsels against unnecessary acquisition, while non-possession discourages the hoarding of surplus property. Bread labour specifies a responsibility for bodily work; swadeshi gives priority to serving neighbours; and nonviolence demands opposition without hatred for one's adversary. These practical rules are necessary for understanding the collective discipline of the ashram.

Page 66 includes, alongside the rejection of untouchability, comments about the varna system. Contemporary readers should understand the historical wording without surrendering critical distance. The demand to abolish untouchability is ethically significant, but a modern understanding of social equality requires ending all forms of caste-based occupational confinement, hierarchy, and exclusion. This contradiction has not been concealed in the present review.

5. The Translator's Linguistic Sensibility and the Texture of Maithili Prose

The clearest feature of the Maithili rendering is its reader-directed prose, close to ordinary speech. Arguments appear in expressions such as 'hamaralokani', 'aor', 'thik', 'karait chhi', 'hoit achhi', and 'kahbak chahi'. The language brings the text nearer to its audience while attempting to avoid both forbiddingly Sanskritized literary prose and incoherence produced by excessively unstructured colloquial speech. Sentences often advance through questions, examples, doubts, and replies. In discussions of truth, nonviolence, and the necessity of vows, this conversational quality allows the reader to participate in the argument.

The translator places philosophical vocabulary within accessible Maithili sentences: satya, ahimsa, brahmacharya, asvad, asteya, aparigraha, abhaya, asprishyata-nivaran, sarva-dharma-samabhava, namrata, and swadeshi. Many terms have Sanskrit origins, but their meanings are developed through concrete examples of food, objects, neighbours, thieves, work, fear, and religion. The explanation of 'bread labour' alongside 'shramavyayi ajivika' provides a particularly useful conceptual bridge. Translation is thus not merely the substitution of words but the presentation of an ordered argument to Maithili readers.

Certain distinctions between terms are important for research. Sarva-dharma-samabhava is not identical in meaning to 'tolerance' or even to the equal honouring of religions: tolerating, regarding equally, and protecting religious rights each raise different questions. Likewise, reducing brahmacharya to sexual abstinence alone would lose its broader sense of governing mind and senses. Comparative study must attend not only to dictionary equivalence but also to ethical meaning in context.

The forms of Maithili spelling in the printed edition have not automatically been treated as errors in the name of modernization. This review analyzes language; it does not manufacture a 'corrected' edition of the source text. Some printed passages show faint marks and blurred letters, so lengthy verbatim quotations have been avoided. That procedure reduces the risk of unverified reconstruction or misquotation.

6. Original and Translation: Evidence and Its Limits

The preface of the English edition mentions letters written from Yeravda prison in 1930 to members of the ashram. This helps establish the historical context of the Maithili book's title Mangal-Prabhat. (Sevagram Ashram, From Yeravda Mandir, title and preface pages)

The published tables of contents broadly overlap in subject: Truth/satya; Ahimsa/nonviolence; Brahmacharya; Control of the Palate/asvad; Non-stealing/asteya; Non-possession/aparigraha; Fearlessness/abhaya; Removal of Untouchability; Bread Labour/shramavyayi ajivika; Equality of Religions/sarva-dharma-samabhava; Humility/namrata; Importance of Vows; and Swadeshi. Some topics occupy different positions or have separate presentations. The English contents also list chapters called 'Yajna or Sacrifice' and 'More About Yajna', without correspondingly titled chapters in the principal Maithili contents. This is a demonstrable difference between their structures. Without seeing the intermediary Hindi edition, however, it would be groundless to assert that 'the Maithili translator removed chapters'.

The comparison points towards further research: the relevant Gujarati original, Amritlal Thakordas Manavati's Hindi translation, and the 2013 Maithili edition should be collated line by line for the number and order of writings, meaning of terms, and examples. The present study has not substituted conjecture for the unavailable intermediary. The boundary of the evidence therefore remains clear.

7. Philosophical and Social Evaluation

The overall philosophical organization can be understood on three levels. First comes personal cultivation: truth, brahmacharya, control of the palate, and humility. Second is an ethics of social resources: non-stealing, non-possession, bread labour, and swadeshi. Third comes coexistence without fear or discrimination: nonviolence, fearlessness, the removal of untouchability, and equal regard for all religions. This threefold scheme is the reviewer's analytical convenience, not an organization of chapters supplied by Gandhi. It

shows how the vows form an interdependent network of practices rather than unrelated moral lectures.

The book's essential strength is its insistence upon testing moral instruction in the conduct of life. Truth is not merely a subject for speeches; nonviolence is not simply opposition to war; brahmacharya is not only a formal oath; non-possession is not just the abandonment of riches; swadeshi is not merely a political slogan. Each concept enters daily choices about meals, acquiring objects, distributing work, community relations, and religion. Gandhian philosophy becomes an ethics of practical experiment rather than a body of abstract principles.

A limitation is its relatively restricted direct analysis of social structures. Personal control over greed, fear, and hatred is essential, but caste, labour markets, landlessness, gender inequality, and violent structures of state authority cannot be eliminated by individual goodness alone. The argument against untouchability, for example, may arouse social conscience, but genuine equality also requires attention to resources, education, representation, and institutional rights. The book offers moral inspiration; modern ethics and the study of social justice provide its critical complement.

At the same time, room must remain for judgement when interpreting the strict form of any vow. Diet according to health, mutual consent in family relationships, work suited to disability, freedom of religious disagreement, and protection of life and property are essential standards when applying Gandhian ethics today. Differences from the text need not be concealed; serious criticism makes respect and disagreement possible together.

8. The Book's Contribution to Maithili Literature

Critical studies of Maithili literature should not be confined to poetry, stories, drama, and folklore. This translation of Gandhi's thinking on conduct contributes to the vocabulary of philosophical prose, social reform, reflection on religion, and public ethics. Concepts such as possession, non-stealing, equal regard, and swadeshi are discussed in familiar Maithili sentence patterns. The language's intellectual capacity is thereby demonstrated not merely in theory but in an actual published text.

The translator's introduction and the documents concerning permission also reveal a cultural fact: bringing the writings of an Indian thinker into Maithili demands linguistic labour, publishing cooperation, and institutional approval. The 2013 edition documents this work. Translation can be a means of democratizing ideas, because readers need not always rely upon Hindi or English mediation to understand them.

This achievement must be evaluated with care. The book does not represent every discussion of Gandhism in Maithili; it is a particular text on the vows of ashram life. A complete history of Gandhian literature in Maithili would require independent study of other journals, books, translations, dates, and modes of publication. The evidentiary reach of this review is limited to this book and the known source tradition.

9. Consolidated Conclusion

The central understanding gained from Mangal-Prabhat is that morality cannot be completed by memorizing the separate headings of a book. Without truth, nonviolence can lose its direction; without nonviolence, a quest for truth may become cruel; without non-stealing, non-possession remains incomplete; without respect for work, swadeshi may become only a slogan about consumption; and without abolishing untouchability and embracing equal regard for religions, personal purification may remain divorced from social justice. Their interdependence is the text's conceptual centre.

The significance of Dr Yoganand Jha's Maithili translation is that ethical reflections written for ashram residents reach a new readership through Maithili prose. Its fifteen principal essays, appendix of eleven vows, introductions, and permission documents together make it an accessible intellectual and publishing record. Its best use lies not in uncritical imitation but as a substantial beginning for reflection on self-discipline, equality, respect for labour, and nonviolent public conduct.

In the final assessment, the book both inspires and generates questions. What form of restraint can respect bodily autonomy? How is religious equal regard connected with equality of rights? How can respect for labour become justice for actual workers? How can opposition to untouchability extend to ending caste hierarchy altogether? How can swadeshi serve neighbours without separating itself from the welfare of humanity? Such questions arise from the book's own ideas. The translation can therefore become not merely an introduction to Gandhian thought in Maithili but a living basis for critical dialogue.

CHAPTER 12 / 2014

Bhore-Bhor: Early in the Morning

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

Central Argument of the Review

Bhore-Bhor is not simply a poem about the benefits of waking early. It attempts to connect a child's daily experience with the observation of nature, family relationships, discipline, the acquisition of knowledge, health, love of country, and altruism. The book contains two compositions: 'Bhore-Bhor' (printed pp. 4–11) and 'Prarthana' ('Prayer', pp. 12–16). The first unfolds the morning and the daily routine across eight sections; in the second, divided into five sections, a child asks for blessings to shape character and social conduct. The arrangement of eight lines on each printed page, accompanied by an illustration, creates a distinct visual route to understanding.

From a literary perspective, the book is notable for the unity between its child-friendly visual presentation and its practical moral instruction. This

unity has limits, however: there is little room for the child's own questions, disagreement, freedom in play, or experiences beyond the prescribed pattern. The child appears chiefly as a learner rather than as someone who creates an independent imaginative world. This criticism arises from the text itself; it is not an unsupported assumption about the intentions of its author or translator.

In examining the translation, the present review concentrates on the available Maithili text: its vocabulary, voice, ordering of lines, repetitions, and ways of addressing children. Because a complete authenticated text of the Hindi original was unavailable, no claim is made about the exact verbal equivalence or divergence of every line. A contemporary published review of the Hindi original, Subah Savere, permits only limited corroboration of the structure and thematic similarities.

1.1 Bibliographic Identification

The inner title page prints 'Translation: Yoganand Jha' and 'Original Hindi: Dr A. Kirtivardhan' beneath the title Bhore-Bhor. The publisher is Vidyalakshmi Prakashan, Muzaffarnagar, Uttar Pradesh. The publication details specify 'First Edition, 2014', name Indian Printing Press as printer, and give the price as 20.00 rupees. In his introductory 'Du Shabd' ('A Few Words'), the translator himself discusses this Maithili rendering of the Hindi children's poetry collection Subah Savere. Together these particulars establish the work's status as a translation.

As external evidence, Videha's book list records this translation as a work of 2014; the Maithil Manch library catalogue likewise identifies the original author, translator, publisher, and year. These two catalogues are used chiefly to verify the book's identity, not as substitutes for reading its text critically. [References 2–3]

The principal evidence for this review consists of the poetic lines, the page-by-page progression of subjects, poetic repetition, the visible details of the illustrations, the texture of the language, and the two introductory texts. Each interpretation is connected to the relevant printed page. The standpoint of the original author is distinguished from that of the translator, while the critic's conclusions form a clearly identified third level. The precise wording of the original Hindi, variant editions of the poems, and direct empirical evidence of readers' responses are unavailable; accordingly no categorical claims about them are made.

2. 'Du Shabd' and 'Nenalokani!': Two Ways of Addressing Readers

2.1 The Translator's Intellectual Preface

'Du Shabd' is more than a conventional preface. The translator connects folklore, children's literature, the mother tongue, linguistic dominance, and the social need for translation. His argument understands children's folk literature as both a form of linguistic expression and a living cultural tradition. He voices concern that linguistic pressures weaken education in the

mother tongue and calls, in particular, for greater activity in writing and reading children's literature in Maithili.

In this preface, translation is understood not as replacing words but as a creative process establishing a relationship between two languages. The translator invokes the term 'loss of translation', acknowledging that some aspect of the original meaning or expression may be lost in transfer. This caution is useful to the critic: a song may sound natural in the target language without its complete equivalence to the source text thereby being established.

The preface also touches on Vedic literature, linguistic history, cultural contact, and translation studies. These broad propositions cannot, however, be independently verified within the book; they are treated here as the translator's intellectual proposals, not as historical findings authenticated by research. Another noteworthy contrast is the change in linguistic difficulty between the preface and the poems: a conceptual, heavily Sanskrit-derived introduction gives way to comparatively short and sonorous poetic lines.

2.2 The Original Poet's Address to Children

In the address headed 'Nenalokani!' ('Children!'; right-hand section), the poet encourages children through short poems to remain cheerful, smiling, and inclined to sing. Birdsong is related to human happiness. The address ends on that page with the original writer's name, 'Kirtivardhan'; it must therefore not be mistaken for the continuation of the translator's 'Du Shabd'.

These two introductory texts have different centres of attention. The translator raises questions of language, culture, and literary transfer; the original poet addresses children's laughter, songs, and well-being. In the poems themselves, the two strands converge: the ease of reading and singing coexists with a dense presence of social and cultural values.

3. 'Bhore-Bhor': A Sequential Reading of Eight Sections (pp. 4–11)

3.1 Page 4: Making Dawn the Beginning of the Daily Routine

The opening line, 'Bhore-sabere jagab sikhu' ('Learn to rise early in the morning'), delivers a direct practical instruction. Expressions such as 'matu-pitake ka pranam' ('offer salutations to your parents') and 'niyat kajme lagab sikhu' ('learn to begin your appointed tasks') link society's behavioural discipline to the child's own routine. The poem does not begin with an abstract ideal; it starts from waking, greeting one's parents, and beginning work. The picture shows a child awakening in bed, dawn at a window, and a clock. Thus the reader experiences 'time' visually as well as verbally.

A critical limitation emerges at the outset: the recurring imperative 'sikhu' ('learn') expects obedience but gives the child no voice with which to express sleepiness, curiosity, or a choice of activity. This may be a familiar technique in the didactic tradition of children's literature, but a modern, participatory classroom would need to pair the instruction with questions and discussion.

3.2 Page 5: The Coexistence of Birds and Children

The second section celebrates the birds' chirping and calls, their singing, movement around the house and courtyard, the offering of water and grain, and the pleasure of seeing them bathe. The illustration depicts two birds on a flowering branch and a child holding a railing. The first page's instruction about 'doing' becomes an enjoyment of 'seeing'. Providing food and water encourages responsibility towards nonhuman life: the child may become not simply a consumer of nature but a companion who cares for it.

This passage seems particularly child-centred, since the birds' movements, sounds, and bathing excite both visual and aural curiosity. Illustration and lines complement the same experience. Yet the depiction of birds as invariably happy and singing is an affectionate poetic personification, not a factual account of avian behaviour.

3.3 Page 6: Air, Bells, and the Practice of Listening

The third section introduces attention to the sky, the enjoyment of fresh air, temple bells, devotional singing, and listening to words of knowledge. The illustration shows a child at a table, a hand cupped to the ear, with a bell and musical symbols in the child's imagination. The focus thus moves from visual description to the practice of listening: the child takes in not only nature's appearance but also the sounds of the surroundings.

The literary complexity lies in the poem's rapid progression from the bodily pleasure of 'pure air' to temple sounds and the ethical idea of 'knowledge'. The section is unified by the 'morning atmosphere', yet brings together three distinct experiences—nature, religion, and learning. Explaining those differences explicitly would make classroom teaching more productive.

3.4 Page 7: The Garden as a Place of Discovery

The fourth section describes walking through a garden with one's father, green trees and plants, the cuckoo's call, the humming of bees, flowers, leaves, and butterflies. The injunction to rise early opens out into a world of sights, sounds, and scents. The illustration places adult and child together; the child's gaze turns towards flowers and flying insects. From the standpoint of young children's experience, this is a particularly effective section: curiosity grows from direct observation rather than moral advice alone.

Walking with one's father represents one particular model of family life. The text does not bring into view the possibility of exploring nature with a grandmother, mother, sister, teacher, or friend. This is a limit of the available poem; it has not been demonstrated to be a difference introduced by the translator.

3.5 Page 8: Moonset and the Expectation of Sunrise

The fifth section describes 'Chanda Mama' (the affectionate 'Uncle Moon'), the blue sky, the moon shining in the west, and the awaited sun in the east. This moment at daybreak lets a child observe temporal change within a single sky. In the picture, the moon appears among mountains and clouds together

with an indication of the rising sun. Both poem and illustration turn the passage from night to day into a playful experience.

The intimacy of 'Chanda Mama' creates an image readily recognizable in Mithila's language addressed to children. Watching the moon become less visible as night turns into day can provide an entry point for elementary scientific learning, but the poem does not expound astronomical principles; its value lies in experiential observation.

3.6 Page 9: Redness in the Sky and the Personification of the Sun

The sixth section describes the reddish eastern sky, sunrise, and the beauty of the heavens. In the illustration, a smiling sun is given a human face, making the vast or unfamiliar celestial body seem like a familiar companion to the child. The sun's gradual ascent provides a natural clock for the entire day, distinct from the motion of leaving one's bed on the opening page.

The poem takes the reader from 'waking' to 'watching the sunrise'. Because of this visual pause amid its instructions, the book becomes more than a list of regular activities. Reading this particular section without its picture would risk losing part of its effect upon a child.

3.7 Page 10: Saluting the Sun and Disciplining the Body

In the seventh section the child salutes the sun. Expressions such as 'ka pranam, da dhyan magan man' (offering salutations with a mind absorbed in meditation) and 'rashmi deh par' (rays upon the body) unite physical, mental, and spiritual practices. The picture depicts a child with folded hands and the sun rising between mountains. Morning nature is now transformed into social and ritual conduct.

The poem associates sunlight with the development of strength and intelligence. This ought to be read as an optimistic, symbolic expression, not as a measured health outcome or a medical claim. The poet relates the experience of light to enthusiasm, alertness, and discipline; scientific or medical evidence is a separate matter.

3.8 Page 11: A Return to the Opening Lesson

The eighth section returns to rising early, clean air, birdsong, protection from illness, saluting one's parents, purity of body and mind, and success in daily tasks. The illustration shows the child greeting the parents respectfully. The concluding section thus brings the first page's message back in a circular pattern: salutations and work at the beginning, salutations and work again at the end. The recurrence makes the poem memorable, although it reinforces familiar instruction rather than presenting a new scene.

A line such as 'rog kono nahi sakat daba' ('no illness can overwhelm [one]') should be treated in textual criticism as rhetorical reassurance, not as a literal, universal guarantee of health. Teaching children's literature responsibly requires making this distinction clear.

4. 'Prarthana': An Extended Reading of Five Sections (pp. 12–16)

4.1 Page 12: Supplication, Knowledge, and Compassion

The second poem, entitled 'Prarthana' ('Prayer'), begins on printed page 12. It opens 'Vinati hamar sunu Bhagavan' ('Hear my supplication, O God'); the child seeks learning, understanding, love for fellow human beings, compassion, and a willingness to help others. The picture shows a child with folded hands facing the figure of a goddess holding a veena. The poem thus presents its ethical values as aspirations for grace, rather than merely as a series of commands.

Here the first poem's external injunction, 'sikhu' ('learn'), becomes a supplication expressed through forms such as 'diah' ('grant'). Both seek ideal behaviour, but the narrative viewpoint changes: in the first poem an adult voice instructs a child; in the prayer the child personally seeks strength and understanding.

4.2 Page 13: The Teacher, Education, and Service to the Family

The second section refers to devotion to one's parents, Ekalavya's devotion to his teacher, the lamp of education, grace, intelligence, love, and compassion. The illustration expresses the child's reverence against a scene resembling a lamp or an arati ritual. Reverence and education occupy the same moral sequence; invoking Ekalavya presupposes some prior acquaintance with his story.

The story of Ekalavya has a complex literary and social background. Reading it merely as an ideal of devotion to the teacher can leave untouched its troubling questions of rights, opportunity, and power relations between teacher and pupil. Retelling the story at an appropriate age, inviting questions, and presenting more than one perspective would provide a more discerning way to teach this verse.

4.3 Page 14: Nation, Durga, and the Metaphor of Knowledge

The third section mentions respect for parents, patriotism, the strength of peace, becoming a worthy child of one's motherland, Durga's power, a blow or collision with a support, and Krishna as an image of knowledge. The illustration depicts a smiling child holding the Indian flag and a book. 'Country' and 'study' therefore become two responsibilities of one child, not separate subjects.

This section contains a plurality of values: devotion, peace, strength, and knowledge. Nevertheless, so many symbolic names condensed into a handful of lines can make the meanings difficult for infants or children in the first school years. Explaining the relation between peace and strength becomes an essential part of interpretation.

4.4 Page 15: Compassion towards Living Beings and Historical Exemplars

In the fourth section lines such as 'Mahavir san bani ahimsak' ('May I become nonviolent like Mahavira') and 'jar-chetan san prem kari' ('May I love

the animate and inanimate') explicitly emphasize nonviolence and compassion. Subsequent lines invoke the Buddha's path of peace, the ideals of Rana and Shivaji, and freedom from fear of enemies. In the illustration a bird-like creature appears close to the child's hand or chest, visually suggesting tenderness towards living beings.

The ideas placed side by side are striking: on one side, nonviolence and love of life; on the other, valour and fearlessness. These need not be dismissed immediately as mutually contradictory, for nonviolence and courage can coexist. Without context, however, a list of exemplars does not explain their differences to children. The passage is therefore a productive starting point for discussing values, but a less self-evident collection of moral maxims.

4.5 Page 16: Karma-Yoga, Service, and a Life without Attachment to Rewards

The concluding section wishes to raise the flag of victory over earth, sky, and the netherworld; to fulfil the dreams of parents, teachers, and kin; to remain constantly engaged in 'karma-yoga'; to work without desire for results; and to lead life with intelligence, strength, and a spirit of service. The picture shows a child holding a flag on mountainous ground. The final image transforms the child awakening in bed at the beginning of the book into an active, nationally conscious, goal-directed figure.

The ethical message of the closing lines goes beyond ordinary 'success' to affirm the importance of service. Yet the combined significance of the 'flag of victory' and 'not desiring the fruits' calls for reflection: the first image represents achievement, while the second denotes detachment from results. Rather than simply identifying this tension as a defect, we should recognize it as an attempt to bring different traditions of moral vocabulary together in one poem for children.

5. Thematic Progression: From the Light of Dawn to the Social Human Being

5.1 The Expansion of Time and Space

The first poem begins with a bed and clock at home, moves through courtyard, garden, sky, and sunrise, and returns to family relationships in the house. The second begins at a place of worship and extends to teachers, nation, exemplary historical figures, and service embracing the whole world. This sequence may be described as a movement 'from the private to the social'. It is an interpretation drawn from the sequence of subjects, not evidence of a plan predetermined by the author.

5.2 The Tension between Sensibility and Discipline

The two poems instruct in different ways. In 'Bhore-Bhor', a speaking voice wakes the child, shows and makes the child hear and offer salutations; in 'Prarthana', the child asks for desirable qualities of mind. The active verbs of the former are a practical strength from the perspective of modern children's literature, but constant instruction may restrict independent imaginative space. When flowers, butterflies, and birds appear, the poem approaches free

delight; when the list of exemplary names becomes dense, information and moral precepts threaten to outweigh song.

5.3 Cultural Pluralism versus a Single Religious Setting

The translator's 'Du Shabd' respects Indian multilingualism and the diversity of forms within folk literature. Yet temple, an image of Saraswati, Durga, Krishna, and salutation to the sun recur in the poems. Recording these religious and cultural symbols describes what is present in the book; it does not authorize assumptions about the religious identities of all its readers. In a classroom containing children of different faiths or secular outlooks, it would be useful to discuss separately the prayer's broadly human values—learning, compassion, nonviolence, and service.

5.4 The Child's Social Position

The illustrations generally foreground a boy; the mother and father appear within the family, while teachers and ideals of nationhood are invoked. Girls' experiences, children with disabilities, children from different social backgrounds, and scenes of collective play receive little emphasis. Recognizing these absences matters not simply as a way of condemning a work from another period, but as a starting point for discussing representation in contemporary children's books.

6. A Critique of Maithili Language, Sound, and Translational Technique

6.1 From 'Subah Savere' to 'Bhore-Bhor'

The published Hindi title is Subah Savere, while the Maithili title is Bhore-Bhor. This change is not merely the exchange of lexical meanings: the repetition of 'bhor' produces a natural rhythm and an intimate sense of time in Maithili oral practice. The repeated 'bhore-sabere' within the poem recalls the title. On these grounds, the translator's choice may be regarded as effective for the target language's sound and the reader's memory. A full comparison of the original title's semantic overtones requires the bibliographic particulars and verified text of the Hindi original.

6.2 Verbal Energy in Maithili and Dialogue with Children

Forms such as 'jagab sikhu' (learn to wake), 'lagab sikhu' (learn to begin), 'dekhab' (to see), 'sunab' (to hear), 'pranam' (salutation), 'kari' (let us do), and 'rahay' (to remain) create movement in the text. This density of verbs gives children a tangible experience: the poem does not merely name objects but urges action or observation. Its suitability for reading aloud to children is enhanced by this verbal dynamism. At the same time, the repetition of 'sikhu' strengthens the instructive voice, making the close relationship between poetry and discipline evident.

6.3 The Coexistence of Familiar Speech and Sanskrit-Derived Vocabulary

Expressions such as 'babuji', 'matu-pita', 'Chanda Mama', 'gachh-birichh', 'chirai', 'pani', 'kaj', and 'bhore-sabere' evoke the intimacy of the local home

and courtyard. Alongside them, 'vishuddha', 'pranam', 'karmayoga', 'ahimsak', 'dayanidhan', 'par-upkarak', and 'matribhumi' introduce Sanskrit-derived ethical vocabulary. The opening lines of the first poem favour everyday speech; the latter parts of the prayer contain denser Sanskritic diction and more exemplary names. This distribution is significant: the language of pleasure in nature is predominantly visual, while the language of moral blessings becomes increasingly conceptual.

6.4 Orality, Repetition, and Memorization

Each printed page of the two poems has the same visual arrangement of eight lines. That fact alone does not justify declaring the verses to follow a particular classical metre or identical quantitative rhythms; such a claim would require systematic phonetic examination of reading aloud, syllabic duration, and pauses at line endings. Nevertheless, their short lines, synonymous pairs, sound-evoking terms, and repetition of 'bhore' lend themselves to memorization. Their usefulness in collective recitation or singing is plausible, not a result established by direct experimental testing.

6.5 The Advantages and Limits of Localization

The Maithili version uses domestic objects, direct address to children, and local nature terms to make the poems readily familiar to speakers of the target language. But a translation's success requires two different assessments: (1) fluency and suitability for children in Maithili, and (2) direct correspondence with the Hindi original in meaning, rhythm, and imagery. The illustrated Maithili text permits substantial criticism by the first standard; the complete Hindi original has not been available for bilingual collation according to the second. Accordingly, this review commends the 'natural Maithili' without awarding an unsupported certificate of 'faithful translation of every line'.

6.6 Specific Questions of Language Editing

The text displays variation in line breaks, punctuation, compounds, and signs indicating pronunciation. Such differences in the printed text should not automatically be classified as errors, especially when children's speech, regional usage, or singability is involved. The title 'Bhore-Bhor' and the song's 'bhore-sabere' perform different functions; mechanically standardizing them could diminish the poetic rhythm. Some characters are uncertain because of faint print or poor reproduction. At those points the original copy must be collated rather than corrections asserted without evidence.

7. Line Drawings: The Joint Creation of Meaning

Nearly every page of verse from pages 4 to 16 contains a prominent illustration. These drawings are not merely ornaments: they offer young readers 'visual sentences' with which to recognize situations. The clock on the first page conveys time; the picture of birds makes seeing and listening concrete; the human faces of moon and sun render unfamiliar celestial bodies familiar; the child's folded hands before the sun give physical form to a

practice; the goddess in the prayer establishes the cultural setting of reverence; and the flag beside a book links service to the nation with study.

Some pictures convey clearer narrative information than the poems. On page 7, for example, the drawing distinctly shows a father and child attentively watching flowers and butterflies; on page 14 the child holds both a book and a flag, whereas the verses range across several values. The visual thus becomes an entrance to ideas for young readers. The near-exclusive depiction of one type of child, however, is also a limitation in representation.

The illustrator could not be clearly identified from the publication details available for inspection; accordingly, no particular drawing has been attributed to a named artist. Nor is an unsupported connection made between the illustrations and any specific artistic school or chronological period.

8. The Limited Use of External Evidence in Reviewing a Translation

A Hindi review of Subah Savere published by Dr Kaushlendra Pandey in 2009 describes a roughly sixteen-page booklet for children containing a long morning song and a second poem of prayer, with illustrations playing a supporting role. It also mentions birdsong, dawn, sky, a garden, filial devotion, Ekalavya, Mahavira, Buddha, Shivaji, and altruism. This thematic sequence corresponds to the material directly visible in the Maithili edition. It confirms that the two texts broadly retain their principal themes, not that their wording or numbers of lines are identical, nor the history of any revisions made in translation. [Reference 4]

An author profile in Sahitya Kunj mentions Subah Savere among Dr A. Kirtivardhan's publications and refers to its Maithili translation. A published literary account from 2019 likewise identifies Subah Savere as an earlier work by the writer. Such evidence helps verify the author's bibliography; it has not been used to invent quotations from inaccessible lines. [References 5–6]

The external review also reveals an interesting difference in critical emphasis: the Hindi reviewer concentrates on praising moral instruction, accessibility, and illustration. The present Maithili study recognizes these qualities but also examines the child's independent voice, gender representation, cultural diversity, the excessive accumulation of exemplars, and the limitations of assertions that sound scientific. The comparison expands the range of critical questions; it does not distort another reviewer's argument.

9. Critical Evaluation: Achievements, Contradictions, and Uses for Readers

9.1 Achievements

The first achievement is the clarity of the poetic purpose: encouraging children to rise early becomes a means of introducing observation, cleanliness, respect within the family, and social compassion. The second is the visual and aural arrangement: morning light, birdsong, bells, the garden's activity, and

pictures each make the poems memorable in their own medium. The third is the accessibility of the Maithili target language: colloquial words and repetitive rhythms open a direct path for ordinary readers. The fourth is the creative relationship between the two poems, which move from practical daily habits towards a desire to serve others.

9.2 Limitations

The first limitation is the commanding voice. Many lines tell children what they ought to do, leaving little room for unexpected discoveries within their own experience. The second is the density of exemplary names: the appearance of Ekalavya, Durga, Krishna, Buddha, Mahavira, Rana, Shivaji, and others within a few lines may fragment the meaning for younger readers. The third is the cultural range of the chosen models: although their values are humanistic, the visual and religious references are concentrated within a comparatively single tradition. The fourth is the exaggeration of certain promises concerning well-being; these should not be mistaken for factual theories of health.

9.3 Concrete Possibilities for Critical Reading in a Children's Classroom

One might work through the illustrations on pages 4–11 by asking, 'What do we see in the morning?' Page 5's passage about birds may lead to conversation about kindness and care towards living beings; pages 8–9 invite comparison of the visible moon and sun; pages 10–11 provide opportunities to distinguish poetic statements from facts about the body, discipline, and health. In 'Prarthana', the compassion of page 12 and the pairing of nonviolence with bravery on page 15 allow children to discuss questions such as, 'Does courage mean violence?' These are educational activities proposed by this review, not exercises printed in the original book.

Especially when reading devotional or dedicatory verses, a school must respect differences of belief and family background. Religious symbols can be studied as part of a cultural text, while broad human qualities such as learning, equal respect, compassion, and service can become grounds of agreement. Such an approach does not suppress the historical voice of the original poem; it enlarges the experience of contemporary readers.

The conclusions of this study fall into three categories. Facts directly supported by the text: the Maithili translation published in 2014, its two poems, the poetic arrangement on printed pages 4–16, thirteen pages with eight lines apiece, the opening linguistic preface, the illustrations, and the analysis of individual lines. Facts supported by external sources: the bibliographic identity of the Hindi original Subah Savere and the thematic correspondence of its two poems as described in the review from 2009. Analytical conclusions: the tension between instruction and pleasure, the collaboration between image and poem, the dense listing of moral exemplars, the question of plurality, and the effect of local Maithili words.

A full test of the linguistic fidelity of the poetic translation would require matching every printed Maithili line to the authenticated first edition of the

Hindi Subah Savere. Such a collation should examine lexical meaning, rhythm, sequence, images, cultural symbolism, the names of exemplary figures, correspondence between pictures, and changes of naming. Without the Hindi original, declaring that a given Maithili line 'departs from Hindi' or 'surpasses the original' would violate scholarly caution.

II. Conclusion: The Literary Place of 'Bhore-Bhor'

At the heart of Bhore-Bhor is not merely the spectacle of darkness lifting at dawn but the transformation of light into a metaphor for the child's mind and conduct. In the first poem, light leads the child from the clock to the sky, from sky to birdsong, and from song to familial affection. In the second, the same child is offered a framework for becoming a person who desires learning, compassion, fearlessness, and service. The poetry is most delicate in scenes of the garden and companionship with living creatures; its didactic urgency becomes most concentrated where exemplary names accumulate. An objective reading must attend to both poles simultaneously.

Dr Yoganand Jha's Maithili translation makes a Hindi children's poetry booklet available to young Maithili readers, and this linguistic accessibility is valuable in itself. Yet praise of the translation cannot conceal the absence of the complete Hindi source text. On the basis of the material actually inspected, Bhore-Bhor may be described as an illustrated booklet of two poems for children, oriented towards moral formation and potentially suitable for singing, in which the values of its own period coexist with questions of continuing relevance to child-centred criticism today.

Visible material	Use in the review
Front and back covers	Title, original author, and translator
Inner title page	Original Hindi author, translator, and publisher
Publication details; opening of “Du Shabd”	2014 edition; arguments on language and children’s literature
Main part of the translator’s “Du Shabd”	Folklore, translation theory, mother tongue
End of “Du Shabd”; “Nenalokani!”	Date of the 2013 preface; address by the original poet
Printed pp. 4–5	Waking and the daily routine; birds and courtyard
Printed pp. 6–7	Fresh air, bells; garden, bees, butterflies
Printed pp. 8–9	Moon and dawn; rising sun
Printed pp. 10–11	Salutation to the sun; respect for parents
Printed pp. 12–13	“Prarthana”: learning, altruism,

Visible material	Use in the review
	respect for teacher
Printed pp. 14–15	Nation, peace, nonviolence, historical exemplars
Printed p. 16; facing page blank	Karma-yoga, service, and conclusion

CHAPTER 13 / 2023

Chaturdash Sutra: Fourteen Critical Threads

A Critical Study of a Work by Dr Yoganand Jha

The Collection's Arrangement and Its Critical Significance

The book is organized into three divisions: six essays under 'Poetic Criticism', three under 'Analysis of Prose', and five under 'Evaluation of Contributions'. The first division chiefly examines hymns to the Ganges, narrative poetry, devotional verse, songs, the portrayal of seasons, and modern reinterpretations of the Ramayana. The second considers a fiction writer's travel writing, the essay as a literary form, and a novel concerned with social philosophy. The third moves beyond individual works to assess the institutional importance of journalism, the scientific structure of language, literary history, biographically informed criticism, and research into folk ballads.

The sequence matters. The first division introduces readers to poetic feeling, imagery, metre, and social consciousness; the second raises questions of theme, technique, milieu, and social transformation; the third turns towards the fundamental instruments of Maithili's modern knowledge system: daily newspapers, grammar, history, the editing of older texts, and preservation of oral traditions. The book's 'threads' thus become not merely the names of fourteen separate writers but fourteen entrances into the character and existence of Maithili literature.

The Philosophy of Criticism in the Preface

In the preface, the writer understands criticism as the integrated work of explication, analysis, and evaluation. For him, the critic is a bridge between reader and creative writer and should consider, as relevant, the work's period and creative process, the author's personality, sociology, linguistics, aesthetics, psychology, and anthropology. He finds both blind praise and fault-finding for its own sake unproductive. This declaration supplies a measure for just criticism; the real test is how far the following fourteen essays sustain such balance.

In many essays the writer brings together a work's basic narrative, lines of poetry, episodes from an author's life, and earlier scholarship. Interpretations gain credibility when the discussion remains close to the original text. Where

a previous writer's opinions, historical possibilities, and the critic's approval merge, there is a particular need to distinguish levels of evidence. The present study tests this methodological question in relation to each subject.

01 | The Tradition of Hymns to the Ganges and Madhup

Original book, printed pp. 17–26

From a River to a Cultural Symbol

The first notable feature of this essay is its extensive historical and cultural introduction. The writer recognizes the Ganges as a river flowing from the Himalayas to the Bay of Bengal, but immediately shows that, for the Indian and Mithila imagination, it is more than a geographical entity. The Ganges has become a foundation of purity, reverence, pilgrimage, funerary rites, and collective memory. References such as 'Ganga Himavatormadhye', Mithila's connection with the southern boundary of the Ganges, Kartik observances on its banks, and Maithili folk songs establish a cultural geography (original work, pp. 17–19).

The writer then seeks the foundations of nature worship, the imagining of the river as mother, and the personification of the Ganges in Indian literature. The passage from practical usefulness to devotional feeling is the essay's underlying argument. Nevertheless, supposing an uninterrupted development from early societies to modern worship is an extremely broad generalization: it is better described as a cultural interpretation than as a historically universal theory. The river's sacred standing is a genuine belief for many communities; miracles and doctrines of salvation associated with that faith should not thereby be treated as historically established facts.

A Sequential Examination of the Literary Tradition

By discussing Valmiki, Vyasa, Kalidasa, Shankaracharya, Panditaraja Jagannatha, and other figures of the Sanskrit tradition, the writer constructs an extensive genealogy of hymns to the Ganges. Turning to Maithili writers—Laldas, Sitaram Jha, Surendra Jha 'Suman', and Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup'—he distinguishes inherited conventions from innovation. Following references to Sitaram Jha's Ambcharit and Suman's Gangatarangini, he examines metaphor, suggestion, extended allegory, and mature imagination in Madhup's Gangatarangavali (pp. 20–26).

Discussing Madhup's verses, the writer considers poetic imaginings of the Ganges as thief, farmer, child, and consort of the ocean, among other figures. Here the centre of criticism comes into focus: not simply the greatness of the Ganges but the poetic devices through which that greatness is expressed. Simile, metaphor, inherited imagery, and a classical lexicon turn a familiar subject into an extraordinary poetic experience. The use of examples accompanied by page references is a strength of the essay's close reading.

Historical Episodes and Evidentiary Caution

The essay also recalls a controversy concerning the river's course in the colonial period. An account of resistance by the then Maharaja of Darbhanga is presented with reference to the 8 May 1915 issue of Mithila Mihir and to Yogmaya Jha's 'Ganga in Maithili Literature' (p. 20). This reference lends Mithila's attachment to the Ganges a political and cultural dimension. Yet a historical examination would require separate inspection of the original news report, government archives, and records of river projects. The resistance described in the book may be regarded as a lead for research, not a fully authenticated history in its own right.

The Essay's New Meaning in the Light of Environmental Questions

In the final portion, the writer depicts modern pollution of the Ganges, alterations to its flow caused by dams and bridges, and an accompanying image of social and political contamination, asking whether a new hymn to the Ganges is needed. This self-questioning turns a historical survey into a contemporary creative challenge. The metaphor of the river's purity becomes connected with moral questions about social life. The idea is powerful, although the scientific condition of water pollution and moral 'pollution' are different orders of assertion and should be connected only through poetic analogy.

In sum, the essay's achievement is to situate Madhup's poetry within a living and long-standing tradition of devotion to the Ganges. Its possible limitation is the tendency in several places to take the river's cultural glory as the primary premise; alternative religious, social, and environmental perspectives receive less attention. Nevertheless, the closing environmental question gives the entire essay a thought-provoking contemporary relevance.

02 | Harimohan Jha's Narrative Poetry

Original book, printed pp. 27–32

Satire in Verse and Its Narrative Significance

Most readers know Harimohan Jha as a writer of humorous and satirical prose. In this essay, Yoganand Jha brings the narrative dimensions of his verse into focus. He discusses seven narrative poems. Each has its own social target, but all share an impulse to expose, through humour, custom, hypocrisy, and inequalities perpetuated in the name of prestige (pp. 27–32).

The writer's first extended example is 'Dhala Jha'. The elderly bridegroom's journey to his in-laws' house, his clothes and manner, linguistic conceit, anger over food, and demand for money at his departure expose mismatched marriage, the bride's helplessness, and the financial exploitation of wedding customs. The humour arises not only from Dhala Jha's eccentric behaviour but from the contradictions of the social order that honours him. It is especially meaningful that the critic looks beyond the caricature of the elderly groom to the bride's family's vulnerability.

Different Forms, One Social Purpose

The analysis moves from 'Tea Party', a satire of the educated community's blind imitation of foreign fashions, to 'Buchkun Baba', concerning women's changing position; 'Nirasan Mama', concerning food taboos and caste difference; 'Salgamak Khand', concerning superstition; and 'Ghutar Kaka', concerning men's psychological resistance to an educated daughter-in-law. 'Buchkun Baba's Dream' also raises the question of family planning. These examples make clear that Harimohan Jha's humour is not detached from reformist values; narrative becomes an instrument of social education.

In 'Nirasan Mama', someone who preaches rigid religious purity violates the rules of civic courtesy; in 'Salgamak Khand', fear of imaginary impurity turns an ordinary meal into a collective crisis. Such episodes derive their satire from the distance between what characters say and what they do. By explaining this mechanism, the writer supplies grounds for understanding Maithili humour as an intellectual form of social criticism rather than merely pleasant entertainment.

The More Subtle Meaning of the Woman Question

Readings of 'Buchkun Baba' and 'Ghutar Kaka' raise questions of women's education, professional independence, marriages without dowry, and a changing balance of power within the family. The writer presents conservative male characters' responses with comic irony. At a deeper analytical level, one must ask whether the target of the humour is not the educated woman but a mentality of authority frightened by her autonomy. Clarifying that distinction is necessary for a modern feminist reading. The essay's evidence permits such an interpretation, though it leaves room to develop it further.

The Strength of the Criticism and Its Formal Limits

A particular strength of this essay is the clear presentation of narrative episodes. It would have been easy to call Harimohan Jha a 'satirical poet' without substantiation; instead, the writer connects events, characters' speech, and social setting. A fuller comparative study of syllabic weight, metre, dramatic dialogue, narratorial position, and emotional movement from humour to pathos across all seven poems would, however, have sharpened our understanding of the form.

The conclusion is not that Harimohan Jha merely mocks social failings. His narrative verse teaches readers to recognize inequalities that violate humanity and arise from rigid convention. The essay makes an important attempt to add the social history of his poetry to a reputation predominantly centred on his prose.

03 | The Poet as Devoted Practitioner: Upendra Thakur 'Mohan'

Original book, printed pp. 33–46

The Poet's Life and the Available Works

This substantial essay surveys the wider field of Upendra Thakur 'Mohan's poetry. Mentioning his village of Chataria, Sanskrit education, and editorial associations with Aryavarta and Mithila Mihir, the writer describes three collections: Phuldali (1942), Baji Uthal Murali (1977), and Itishri (1982). The book also records that Baji Uthal Murali received the Sahitya Akademi award in 1978 (pp. 33–34). Such historical information helps establish the chronology of the works.

Love, Revolution, and the Other Meaning of Song

By discussing the two divisions of Phuldali, 'Shringarkusum' and 'Krantikusum', the writer identifies two emotional territories of creation. The passion of romantic love and the call for revolution need not be opposed: both possess intense emotional energy. Mohan's songs contain appeals for national regeneration, awakening, youth responsibility, and collective welfare. Discussing his image of the 'navgachhuli' (new sapling), the writer connects reconstruction with nature's vital power. Here musical rhythm and social proclamation reinforce one another.

Mohan's Sanskrit learning influences his metre, rasa, syntax, and inherited symbols; it does not follow that his poetry is withdrawn from contemporary life. The essay examines his responses to social decline, national crisis, ethical responsibility, the suffering of the poor, and the contradictions of modernization. In this sense the poet is a 'sadhak'—not merely a spiritual ascetic but a writer who seeks the values of life through disciplined language.

Fidelity to Metre and the Changes of an Era

The writer emphasizes that Mohan chiefly composed lyrical verse intended for singing. Attention to quantitative and syllabic metres, pauses, terminal rhyme, and the voice of recitation is a lasting feature of his work. Some unmetered compositions reflecting the times are also noted. This raises a fundamental critical question: does innovation necessarily arise from abandoning metre? The evidence of the essay suggests that it does not. Language, symbolism, and social questions can be innovative even where the metre remains traditional.

Evaluating a Poetic Personality

From Mohan's poems, the writer brings out the coexistence of classical cultivation and reformist consciousness. Criticism of social rigidity, hypocrisy, and incongruity, appeals to youth, and hopeful statements are important textual evidence for the assessment. Even so, judging the quality of the verse would have benefited from closer comparative investigation of musical performance, sound patterning, and changes in diction across poems of different periods.

The essay's contribution is to examine Mohan's creative development through three collections rather than merely introducing him as an award-winning poet. Its implicit critical lesson is that poetry cannot be understood by automatically treating traditional form as conservative or new metre as progressive.

04 | Snehalata's Love of Mithila and Maithili

Original book, printed pp. 47–53

Devotion and Attachment to a Cultural Geography

'Snehalata's Love of Mithila and Maithili' is not merely an appreciative reading of devotional verses; it makes Mithila's cultural geography the centre of the poetry. Placing Snehalata within the traditions of devotion to Rama and madhurya-upasana (devotional worship conceived through sweetness and intimacy), the writer discusses works such as Vaidehi Vivah Sankirtan, Vinay Padavali, Sneh Shatak, Sneh Vatika, Jhula Sankirtan, Maheshvani Sangrah, Chetavani Sankirtan, and Sitavataran (pp. 47–49). This introduces both the range of the writer's compositions and the religious-social practices surrounding the poetry.

The Idealization of Mithila in Maithili Devotional Lyrics

In Snehalata's verses Mithila is the land of Janaka and Janaki. Its soil, customs, seasons, language, memories of marriage, and intimate relationships together create an image of sacred homeland. Through cited verses the writer shows that celebration of Mithila involves not simply place names but cultural feeling and linguistic intimacy. Devotional lyrics become the language of regional identity through this form of love for the motherland.

The discussion of a line expressing the feeling 'I shall pass my days gathering greens and leaves' is especially revealing. Even amid poverty it insists upon not abandoning the land of birth. This is a tension between social reality and a devotional ideal. The poet does not present Mithila as wholly prosperous; rather, deprivation cannot persuade him to sever his cultural attachment. Here devout and emotive poetry touches a real social question.

A Sense of Language and Other Linguistic Influences

The writer shows that, although Snehalata drew inspiration from traditions of Hindi Rama devotion, Tulsidas's poetry, and various devotional lyric traditions, the fundamental medium of expression remained Maithili. The relation between acknowledging sources and creatively transforming them in one's own language is not merely imitation but cultural reconstruction. The writer reads lyrics about the sweetness of Maithili as evidence of regional self-respect. Linguistic consciousness does not stand apart from religious devotion; it becomes an intimate part of it.

Room for Critical Debate

The principal tone of the essay is affirmative. The writer's sympathy for Snehalata's devotion, attachment to the mother tongue, and ideal image of

Mithila is evident. Yet more could have been said about the classical foundations of madhurya-upasana, intertextual parallels with the Tulsidas tradition, the voices of women, and differences within actual social hierarchies. Verses celebrating Mithila's cultural excellence should be read as a poetic construction of regional ideals, not as an exact picture of society in every period.

Despite this limitation, the essay establishes that, in studying a devotional poet's 'love of Mithila', language is not merely a medium but also a subject. The poet's attachment to the mother tongue and devotion to Sita mutually confer dignity upon one another.

05 | Lyricist Pradeep's 'Swayamprabha'

Original book, printed pp. 54–62

Selecting a Little-Known Episode of the Ramayana

The essay situates Prabhunarayan Jha 'Pradeep's Swayamprabha within the development of Maithili Ramayana poetry and narrative verse. The writer first discusses earlier Maithili traditions of the Rama story—Jyotirishwar, Vidyapati, Chanda Jha, Laldas, and various folk songs. This history aims to show that the Ramayana is not a single unchanging work, but a shared cultural resource acquiring fresh meanings across different periods (pp. 54–57).

Swayamprabha is a character from the Rama narrative whose episode is identified with the Kishkindha Kanda of the Adhyatma Ramayana. The search for Sita, a band of monkeys, a dark cave, thirst, their meeting with the yogini Swayamprabha, and the assistance she provides form the narrative foundation. Pradeep adopts the story, but, according to the critic, his final creative purpose is not merely to repeat an ancient tale.

Modern Social Questions Raised through a Mythological Source

The innovative turn comes when Swayamprabha is called upon to become a luminous force against the plight of women in modern Mithila, the demon of dowry, and oppression within marriage. The mythic yogini thereby becomes an emblem of social resistance. This conjunction of the Ramayana's inherited moral dignity with contemporary women's suffering is a central artistic device of the work. To show the change, the writer compares the older narrative with the poet's imaginative extension (pp. 58–62).

In considering originality, it is essential to distinguish an inherited plot from the distinct artistic act of using it for a modern problem. From this perspective, Swayamprabha is not imitation but reinterpretation. The work deploys a figure of religious authority in the cause of social reform; the effectiveness of that authority for human equality must, however, be evaluated through the character's actual agency.

The Work of Language, Rasa, and Metre

The writer judges the narrative poem's language simple, intelligible, and characterized by the classical quality of clarity known as prasada-guna. He

regards the use of Sanskrit-derived words alongside inherited and indigenous forms as evidence of natural Maithili writing. Devotion remains part of the story's background, but does not simply become preaching; it supports the desire to educate the public. Discussing several quantitative metres and terminal rhymes, the writer also identifies some instances of irregular rhythm. This qualification prevents the review from becoming uncritical praise.

Achievement of Form and Outstanding Questions

The essay maps a comparative route from the Ramayana poetic tradition to the modernity of narrative verse. A verse-by-verse comparison between the source text, Pradeep's poem, and possible other Ramayana versions would, however, better establish the boundaries of his innovations. Feminist study could also illuminate the representation of women, Mithila's social reality, and the capacity of its symbolism to sustain resistance.

The essay's lasting significance is its identification of a creative process that connects a mythic source with a modern problem. Swayamprabha's divine 'radiance' becomes, in this sense, a social metaphor for dispelling the darkness of dowry.

06 | Dr Jayamant Mishra's 'Kavita Kusumanjali'

Original book, printed pp. 63–78

Sanskrit Scholarship and Creation in the Mother Tongue

The writer opens this essay by examining the historical relationship between Sanskrit and Maithili literature. Sanskrit scholars writing in Maithili have often been charged with conservatism. Challenging that generalization, he regards Jayamant Mishra's editorial scholarship, classical training, and love for his mother tongue as two expressions of a single intellectual life. Listing Sanskrit works edited by Mishra, he seeks to establish the scholar's commitment to research (pp. 63–66).

From Devotional Cultivation to the Sensibility of the Seasons

Kavita Kusumanjali contains invocations to Saraswati, hymns to Krishna, classical images, songs drawing on ragas, and poems depicting the seasons. The critic suggests comparisons between Mishra's poetry of Krishna's sweetness and the devotional current of Vallabhacharya's Madhurashtakam. This approach seeks originality not only in unprecedented subject matter, but also in a linguistic recreation of previously established devotional feeling.

The poems devoted to six seasons extend the sensuous range of the collection through clouds, summer, autumn, the early and late winter seasons, and spring. References to Nag Panchami, Madhushravani, and Mithila's festivals make the seasons more than natural conditions: they become social time. When the writer discusses a line that raises compassion for people suffering from winter's cold, he reveals the entrance of social sympathy into the personification of nature (pp. 69–72).

The Central Dispute about Innovation

The writer pays special attention to the modern uncertainty suggested by a line such as 'Where am I continually going?' He connects this poetic self to questions of progress, loss of self-awareness, and selfishness in an era. Poetry in classical metres can also express modern doubt, social contradictions, and tensions between individual and collective existence. The essay's principal argument becomes clear here: the history of form must be distinguished from the history of ideas.

Critical Considerations

The writer's argument is strongest where poetic examples are used to re-examine the easy accusation of 'conservatism'. The range of devotion, nature, and social consciousness prevents a one-dimensional interpretation of the book. Still, the chronology of publication, the limits of imitation of Sanskrit verses, actual metrical scansions, and variants of seasonal imagery offer further scope for research. Skill in classical metres and poetic excellence are not identical: each requires its own standard of judgement.

This essay's valuable achievement is its refusal to equate classical cultivation in Maithili with hostility to innovation. The study of Jayamant Mishra's poems thereby becomes a shared field embracing language, scholarship, folk life, and historical consciousness.

07 | Fiction Writer Nagendra Kumar's 'Shyamali'

Original book, printed pp. 79–89

From the Tradition of Fiction to Travel Writing

Although 'fiction writer' appears in the essay's title, the author understands Shyamali primarily as a literary account connected with a journey to Ireland. The opening discusses the development of Maithili fiction, its progression from social reform to realism, and Harimohan Jha's influence. This broad introduction is intended to establish Nagendra Kumar's literary position, although the reader must wait some time before discovering the precise genre of Shyamali (pp. 79–82).

The listing of Nagendra Kumar's story collections Sasarfani, Drishtikon, Shikar, and Falena Jamun, together with Yoganand Jha's disagreement with an earlier critic who denied him the status of an 'original short-story writer', turns the essay into a debate within the history of criticism. The author does not equate influence with imitation. A writer may draw inspiration from another and still be original in experience, presentation, and subject. This is reasonable, though the ultimate evidence would be stronger with direct story-by-story comparisons.

The Distinctive Range of 'Shyamali'

According to the author, Shyamali is a literary record of a visit to Ireland during the writer's stay in England, said to have been published by the Maithili Akademi, Patna, in 1981. He proposes a possible relationship with the

Hindi travel narrative Pathchari as a conjecture; it would be improper to treat that possibility as a proven textual connection. The work's social, political, cultural, and educational observations are important to the discourse of travel literature: women's public participation, Irish aspirations for independence, correspondences with India's independence movement, and concerns about the future of the mother tongue (pp. 83–89).

The experience of Ireland leads the writer to question the future of Maithili. Abandoning one's language for another deemed more prestigious, the small readership for literature, and the need to protect one's mother tongue become sharper through comparison with the country visited, not separately from it. One country's experience becomes a means of linguistic self-examination for another. A reading of Shyamali is consequently also a study of self-critical Maithili consciousness within travel writing.

Narrative Style and the Structure of the Account

The critic identifies compact dialogue, rich information, and the power to create scenes as qualities of Shyamali. He also notes that descriptive passages sometimes become excessively long, while arguing that their informative content sustains interest. This judgement exposes the tension between information and aesthetic experience: how much documented detail belongs in travel literature, and how much imaginative reconstruction may a historical account accommodate?

A Balanced Judgement

The essay's strength is its recognition of Shyamali's generic independence beyond its author's established reputation as a fiction writer. Its weakness is that a more detailed analysis was possible of the relations among travel diary, dialogue, memoir, and creative reconstruction. Verifying the historical information about Ireland against independent sources and establishing actual textual parallels with Pathchari would be productive directions for further research.

08 | Mayanand Mishra's Essays

Original book, printed pp. 90–101

The Essayistic Personality of a Fiction Writer

Mayanand Mishra is generally introduced as a writer of stories and novels; here Yoganand Jha retrieves his relatively neglected identity as an essayist. He relates Mayababu's Maithili broadcasts, editorial work, public cultural life, and activities in the literary movement to his prose. The critic observes that the available essays are dispersed among magazines and journals. Organizing them by subject and thereby giving readers the framework of a possible collected volume is a concrete achievement of the essay's research (pp. 90–95).

The Intellectual Concerns of the Critical Essays

The writer considers essays including 'The Condition and Consequences of Maithili Fiction', 'Schools of Thought in Modern Maithili Poetry', 'Modern

Maithili Poetry: Driving Forces and Trends', 'Awareness of the Responsibility of Criticism', 'Searching the Ground of Maithili Fiction', and essays on Vidyapati. Mayababu's central concern is with new subject matter, human values, symbols, and techniques of expression. An idea quoted from an early editorial in the magazine Abhivyanjana becomes important evidence of his poetics.

An essay on schools of thought in modern Maithili poetry questions the mechanical adoption of categories from Hindi criticism. Drawing upon Maithili's own experience, Mayababu proposes categories such as maryadavada, sanskritivada, prakritivada, and abhivyanjanavada (pp. 96). Their intellectual significance lies in the ambition to write literary history through concepts grounded in the language's own traditions. Yet without directly examining the boundaries, historical utility, and groupings of writers under these four categories, they should not be accepted as a conclusively proven system.

The Prose of Memoir and Movement

The writer moves beyond literary criticism to examine Mayababu's memoirs, writing on movements, prefaces, and congratulatory prose. 'My Journey on the Stage' combines literary performance spaces, employment, public life, and autobiographical feeling. An essay on the 'Maithili Struggle Campaign' conveys a participant's view of the language movement. 'The Library Movement' proposes redirecting spending on ceremonies towards libraries and publishing infrastructure. In these works, the essay is not simply an aesthetic object but a practical instrument of the linguistic public sphere (pp. 98–100).

Discussing an essay commemorating a political figure of Mithila, the critic notes figurative language, energetic sentences, and praise of a historical individual. The critic's responsibility here also includes distinguishing encomium from authenticated history. Yoganand Jha gives appropriate place to the prose's aesthetic qualities, but the need for critical distance in judging a person remains.

A list of essays containing references to their journals, years, and pages could form the basis for future textual editing. The writer himself calls for a comprehensive collection of Mayababu's scattered essays. This demand is extremely important for scholarship: without the original essays, the history of the fiction writer's intellectual development will remain incomplete.

The essay's strength is its refusal to neglect a supposedly 'minor' genre and its connection of the writing to the author's intellectual and social activities. Its limitation is that the predominantly affirmative statements call for more textual criticism of weaknesses in reasoning, inner contradictions, repetition, and linguistic change. Nevertheless, the essay provides a solid beginning for collecting and classifying the materials of the Maithili essay tradition.

09 | Social Philosophy in Viditji's 'Gram-Ganarajya'

Original book, printed pp. 102–136

The Novel between Realism and Idealism

The essay on Gram-Ganarajya is the longest in the collection's prose division. The critic begins by distinguishing realism's unvarnished observation of society from idealism's ethical aspirations. Vidyanath Jha 'Vidit's novel is placed among works that expose Mithila's shortcomings without reservation while ultimately seeking possibilities for public welfare. According to the critic, Gram-Ganarajya is Viditji's fifteenth novel, published in January 2013; the earlier course of his novel-writing is also described (pp. 102–104).

The Creative Arrangement of Seventeen 'Ullas'

The novel's seventeen divisions are called 'ullas'. The first three establish the main plot and the basis for the journey. In subsequent episodes, various living souls observe and experience Mithila's society; the seventeenth and final ullas moves towards a synthesis of these experiences (pp. 104–107). The writer analyses this extensive structure in sequence. Each ullas becomes at once an independent episode, a social case study, and a piece of the larger picture of Mithila.

The use of an outsider's perspective for society's self-examination is an important narrative device. Through the experiences of souls associated with Arunachal, Kinnaur, Kerala, Punjab, Kashmir, Bengal, and other regions, Mithila's everyday life is measured against life elsewhere. Travel and dialogue become tools for listing social maladies. Yet whenever exposition of ideas takes precedence over the movement of the plot, the novel risks turning essayistic. The tension between literary form and social instruction is therefore a central critical question.

Women, Family, and Social Resistance

The discussion of the fourth ullas recounts women creating arrangements for shelter, conversation, and reconciliation for other women estranged from their families. This episode makes domestic anger, insult, and impulses towards self-destruction matters for collective resolution. The fifth ullas discusses contradictions arising from marriage arrangements and dowry. An important possibility here is to read women's dignity as a matter of social justice and independent life rather than confining it within the family's code of honour.

Some episodes praise educated or active women. Even so, it would not suffice to limit women's concerns to restoring harmony at home. Social security, freedom in decision-making, and control over economic resources are implicitly raised; examining all three more fully would clarify the strengths and limits of the novel's social philosophy.

'Budbak Hotel': Business, Advertising, and Irony

In the sixth ullas, the story of Vaikuntha's 'Budbak Hotel' becomes a particularly pointed satirical image. His earlier period as a driver, meeting the celebrated dancer Mallika, starting a business, naming the hotel, growing competition, dividing the hotel among his sons, and attracting customers through advertising reflect a changing economic world. Around pages 114–118, the critic considers the story in relation to entrepreneurship, commercial ingenuity, capital investment, and the influence of publicity in Mithila.

The transformation of 'budbak', a term of disparagement, into a commercial brand is interesting from the perspective of sociolinguistics. A comic name acquires market value. Further analysis could raise questions about the worth of labour, informal employment, and the changing ethics of an advertising-driven society.

Migration, Consumerism, and Communal Divisions

Later ullas depict the exploitation of migrant workers, the departure of young people from Mithila, religious pretension, administrative malpractice, consumerist lifestyles, selfishness within families, caste divisions, and political greed. At suitable points, the critic recalls Mithila's ancient learning, Udayanacharya, Kumarila Bhatta, Vachaspati Mishra, and the figures of Janaka and Sita. This becomes a moral measure against which present failings are judged; nevertheless, celebrating past glory cannot substitute for practical solutions to contemporary problems.

The dignity of labour is an important thread in the novel. The writer connects Janaka's discovery of Sita with the ethical worth of agricultural work. The underlying sentiment is that Mithila should stand upon its own labour rather than anyone else's favour. The need to abandon self-interest, inertia, false prestige, and inactivity for collective progress is emphasized in different episodes.

The Mother Tongue and the Ideal of a Village Republic

Towards the ending, caste, religion, varna, jealousy, false pride, deception, wastefulness, and lack of fellow-feeling are depicted as constraints upon Mithila's future. In the critic's conclusion, the development of Maithili language and literature and social harmony define the novel's horizon of possible solutions (pp. 132–136). This binds its multifaceted narrative world into a cultural and moral proposal.

A critical question is essential here: will the advancement of the mother tongue alone eliminate social and economic injustice? Language is certainly the basis for collective self-respect and communication, but land, employment, education, caste power, and government accountability have institutional dimensions of their own. Debate is needed about how closely the novel connects love of language to political and economic programmes.

Evaluating the Long Essay

The writer recounts the plot of each ullas at length, enabling readers who have not read the novel to gain an extensive understanding of its social episodes. This is useful, but descriptive detail sometimes pushes the critical argument into the background. The review could have been more analytical through independent discussion of novelistic time, narrator, characterization, the naturalness of dialogue, registers of language, the credibility of the final ideal as literature, and formal discipline in managing the novel's length.

Nevertheless, the essay can be regarded as an important exercise in Mithila's self-criticism. The critic reads Gram-Ganarajya as something like a moral X-ray of Mithila's society; the most important lesson is that attachment to one's region does not require silence about its failings.

10 | Acharya 'Suman's Daily Newspaper 'Swadesh'

Original book, printed pp. 137–147

A Significant Episode in the History of Maithili Daily Newspapers

This essay shifts from evaluating literary figures to the institutional history of journalism. Discussing the scarce tradition of daily newspapers in Maithili, Yoganand Jha regards Acharya Surendra Jha 'Suman's Swadesh as a courageous experiment in the public potential of the mother tongue. The writer's comments on contemporary Maithili dailies belong to the period in which the original essay was composed; they cannot be treated as a complete list of newspapers operating in 2026 (p. 137).

The First Experiment: Language Consciousness and News for the Public

The book gives examples from Swadesh issues of 1955, including editorials, poems, local notices, and satirical columns. The first run is said to have ceased on 27 December 1955. Details of the prices of goods in Darbhanga markets, railway timings, sports, cinema news, literary comment, and public information demonstrate that Swadesh was not merely a literary magazine: it was an experiment in the full circulation of information about civic life in Maithili (pp. 138–141).

The newspaper's satirical writing is especially notable. Through village speech, proverbs, familiar turns of phrase, and comic characters it developed Maithili's possibilities as a 'newspaper language'. The writer rightly observes that standardization means more than producing Sanskritized editorials; it also involves giving ordinary people's speech a dignified public printed form. Vernacular language and popular journalism thereby develop one another.

The Second Experiment: The Question of Economic Foundations

The latter part discusses attempts to revive Swadesh. It considers the efforts of the 'Swadesh Goshti', appeals for editorial support, the impact of financial obstacles on the paper's size and regularity, the printing operation, workers, and difficulties of distribution. By noting missing editorials and irregularity in

some issues, the writer goes beyond celebrating the newspaper's emotional significance to investigate the causes of its institutional weakness (pp. 142–147).

Columns devoted to public opinion, local affairs, world affairs, satire, and discussion of ideas created a many-sided newspaper. The various titles of Chandranath Mishra 'Amar's satirical column and the works of Maithili writers published in it made the newspaper a shared intellectual meeting place. References to first or earlier appearances of writers' work are significant for future literary history, although precise chronology should be established by collating the original issues.

A Methodological Contribution

The essay's distinctive achievement is to reconstruct the linguistic and public functions of the newspaper from descriptions of its printed contents. Being a 'daily' is understood not simply as appearing every day but as representing everyday social consciousness in the mother tongue. In the writer's view, Swadesh left a legacy, but the absence of strong financial institutions prevented its permanence. This conclusion calls attention to the difference between literary endeavour and the infrastructure of journalism.

Further research would require a systematic inventory of all surviving issues, publication dates, distribution areas, editorial responsibilities, letters from readers, advertisements, and payments to contributors. Without these details, assessments of its social reach must remain cautious. Even so, the essay on Swadesh is an important introductory and critical source for researching public journalism in Maithili.

II | Linguistic Study of Maithili and Subhadra Jha

Original book, printed pp. 148–154

The Question of a Language's Structural Independence

The essay centres on Dr Subhadra Jha's linguistic scholarship, particularly The Formation of the Maithili Language. It presents the work as an intellectual attempt to establish Maithili's independent status through concrete analysis of sounds, forms, vocabulary, grammatical categories, and linguistic relationships, rather than merely through emotional identification. The writer relies on Subhadra Jha's classifications of the languages of his time and views expressed in English (pp. 148–150).

Language Families and Comparison

According to the critic, Subhadra Jha compares the geographical range, dialects, early records, scripts, and development of Maithili with Bhojpuri, Magahi, Bengali, Assamese, Odia, Nepali, and other languages. The essential question is which features derive from shared historical origins and which display Maithili's distinct grammatical organization. Political naming and structural classification proceed through different forms of reasoning in linguistics. The cited position is important because Maithili's distinctness is argued from its linguistic morphology.

Historical language classifications have changed over time. An earlier scheme cannot therefore be presented as the final consensus of modern linguistics. The essay's achievement lies in setting out and evaluating Subhadra Jha's arguments, not in declaring the present standing of every historical classification.

Word Formation and the Question of Suffixes

The writer takes particular interest in Subhadra Jha's morphological examples: the historical development of endings such as 'thi', 'auti', and 'auri', comparisons with alleged bases including kastha, pattika, and vatika, and the introduction of prefixes such as 'be-', 'bad-', and 'hed-' as examples of language contact (pp. 150–151). Two levels must be distinguished: the present use of forms in Maithili is a directly observable linguistic fact, while their ancient derivations are separate historical hypotheses requiring regular sound correspondences and evidence from older texts.

Subhadra Jha's discussion of diminutive, augmentative, and highest-degree nominal forms demonstrates Maithili's morphological richness. Their use is affected by context, respect, size, intimacy, and dialectal variation; one form should not be presumed to apply obligatorily to every noun. The critic notes Subhadra Jha's own caution. Grammatical examples in this chapter thus become evidence of Maithili society's linguistic life, rather than merely lists of word classes.

Criticizing the 'Sanskrit Mould'

The latter part criticizes attempts to force Maithili grammar into the structure of Sanskrit or Hindi grammar. Linguistic analysis should begin with actual usage, not predetermined classical categories—this is a compelling conclusion of the section. It remains highly relevant because language teaching, lexicography, spelling guides, and computational language resources all need to respect the source language's distinctive practices.

Critical Assessment and Future Directions

The writer connects structural linguistic independence with cultural self-respect. A limitation is that this brief essay cannot fully examine comparative phonological tables, complete paradigms of verbs, actual regional dialect data, or competing etymological theories. It should therefore be treated as an evidential introduction to Subhadra Jha's contribution, not as a comprehensive modern reassessment of his linguistics.

The methodological requirement raised here retains its force: Maithili must be understood through its own actual sounds, forms, sentences, and social usage.

12 | Jayakant Mishra's Contribution to the Development of Maithili Literature

Original book, printed pp. 155–166

From Literary History to Active Language Advocacy

The essay on Dr Jayakant Mishra combines literary history, research, and public activism. The writer discusses Mishra's education, university research, attempts to write a history of Maithili literature, and links with literary institutions. The English-language A History of Maithili Literature is judged important because it enabled the antiquity, continuity, and range of Maithili literature to reach an international scholarly audience (pp. 155–160).

Gathering Sources and the Practical Labour of Literary Historiography

Literary history is understood not as a list of poets but as the collective intellectual labour of locating records, identifying texts, determining chronology, understanding linguistic change, and classifying currents of literature. The writer recalls earlier attempts at literary historiography and regards Jayakant Mishra's work as more integrated, comparative, and fully referenced. This judgement requires care: although Mishra's work is rated highly, an exhaustive comparison with the whole field of literary history would be a substantial separate undertaking.

The discussion of Mishra's use of English for literary history also touches cultural politics. English can introduce Maithili to international academic conversations, but intellectual vocabulary must also develop within the mother tongue. Out of this tension emerges a two-level strategy: reach readers outside the community while cultivating a reading culture within it.

Maithili's Position within Indian Literary Institutions

The critic attributes particular importance to Jayakant Mishra's correspondence, arguments, and public work for recognition of Maithili in Indian literary institutions. The original essay mentions the Sahitya Akademi's recognition of Maithili in 1965 and quotes views attributed to Jawaharlal Nehru (pp. 163–165). These are significant leads for the institutional history of Maithili, but reconstructing the full history of official decisions would require independent inspection of the Akademi's original records, letters, and other activists' contributions. The critic himself raises the question of crediting a collective movement to one individual; that methodological caution is welcome.

Education, Social Initiatives, and Linguistic Dignity

The essay refers to using Maithili in primary education, the Maithili Mahila Vidyapith, an All India Radio station, and different aspects of the language movement. Jayakant Mishra thus emerges not only as a scholar in a library but also as a social worker beyond it. A mother tongue's dignity is realized in education, publication, communication, and administrative life—a message repeatedly present in the essay.

Critical Balance

The essay is valuable for connecting an intellectual biography with institutional history. Yet levels of evidence must be kept separate when discussing an individual's dedication, the collective achievements of a movement, and the causes of state decisions. The writer's admiration is often grounded in genuine achievements; examining opposing positions, other major campaigners of the period, and institutional documents would nevertheless produce a more varied perspective.

Even so, this assessment clarifies that the modern development of Maithili literature is not only the history of producing literary works; it is also the history of building a knowledge system and gaining public recognition for the language.

13 | 'Sajivani Criticism': Ramdev Jha

Original book, printed pp. 167–208

A Distinctive Metaphorical Conception of Criticism

The book's longest essay, 'Sajivani Criticism: Ramdev Jha', introduces Dr Ramdev Jha's personality, literary work, rediscovery and editing of older Maithili texts, engagement with classical criticism, and research-based criticism centred on writers. The critic identifies a method in which the writer's life, contemporary circumstances, archives, manuscripts, bibliography, and the work's beauty illuminate one another. 'Sajivani' means more than biography; it means revitalizing textual interpretation through the circumstances of lived experience (pp. 167–169).

Dr Ramdev Jha died on 18 March 2021, and the book is dedicated to his memory. The writer's personal gratitude shapes the essay's voice, giving the appraisal a clear element of affection. Such closeness can supply valuable research knowledge, but a critical judgement also requires some distance from it.

Rediscovery and Editing of Older Texts

The writer describes Ramdev Jha's editions and publications of older song and dramatic works, including Nandipati Gitimala, Ramvijay Nat, Hargauri Vivah, Kunjvihar, Dashavatar Nrityam, Shodashgitam, and Mudit Kuvalayashva. This labour has profound historical utility: preparing reliable copies of texts, determining authorship, identifying relationships between manuscripts, and understanding the actual shape of dramatic traditions are foundations of literary history. Knowledge advances through discovering the original materials themselves, not merely through broad critical conclusions.

Shankardev and Relations between Assam and Mithila

The discussion of Shankardev of Assam reviews Ramdev Jha's interpretations in his introduction to Ramvijay. It examines the Vaishnava religious movement, ankiya drama, linguistic forms mixed with Maithili, and connections between Assam and Mithila's dramatic traditions (pp. 170–172).

These relations raise questions of literature's movement across boundaries. Linguistic mixing should be understood not as 'corruption' but as evidence of historical creative contact.

Nevertheless, the classification of Assamese, Brajabuli, and dramatic languages containing Maithili elements is a complex historical problem. Claims would become more securely evidenced by examining older texts, local traditions, and modern linguistic arguments separately. The critic's discussion provides a useful point of entry.

Jagajjyotirmalla's Works and Their Authorship

The discussion of Ramdev Jha's research on Jagajjyotirmalla's dramatic songs is particularly noteworthy. Examining an earlier attribution of Mudit Kuvalayashva to Vanshamani, Ramdev Jha is said to have reinterpreted a phrase in the play's prologue and identified its author (pp. 173–175). This is an example of text-centred historical reasoning. Authorship cannot be determined simply by seeing a name: the prologue, stage-manager's words, other passages, and evidence from related works must be compared.

The discussion of acts, jamanika, prologue, rasa arrangement, entrances, and performance technique on classical principles shows Ramdev Jha's breadth of critical learning. Yoganand Jha joins the application of classical theory to historiography; the result is criticism of artistic practice, not mere description.

Jagatprakashamalla and the Classification of Dramatic Songs

The essay discusses Jagatprakashamalla's songs, plays, sources, arrangement of rasas, and classifications of song forms (pp. 177–180). It pays attention to Ramdev Jha's distinctions, especially those between dramatic songs and independent lyrical songs, and to the territories of erotic and devotional feeling. This shows the importance of looking at literary history through music, performance, and poetic form. A complete assessment of lyrics from their printed words alone is difficult; knowledge of performance traditions, raga contexts, and surviving musical practices would enrich the study.

Nandipati and Dating through Genealogies

In criticism concerning Nandipati, the author describes testing previously accepted lines of descent by using genealogical references in theatrical prologues and panji genealogical records (pp. 181–183). Here the critic's task extends beyond aesthetic judgement to interpreting records that serve as historical evidence. Nevertheless, panji registers, genealogies, literary prologues, and historical chronology do not always agree. The character of the evidence, possible copying errors, and the recurrence of similar names must always be considered.

Jivan Jha: A Transition in the Theatre

Discussion of the poet Jivan Jha's plays forms another important section of the long essay. Ramdev Jha's conclusions concern the decline of kirtaniya theatre, the spread of Parsi theatre, staging of Ramlila, and the changed structures of Maithili drama (pp. 184–190). The cultural place of the Janakpur

lila and Maithili as the spoken language of Ramlila supply context for Sitaparinay. Distinguishing a purported source from an original work requires consideration of plot, characters, division into acts, and language.

Re-examination of earlier opinions on the originality of Jivan Jha's Samavati Punarjanma, together with the search for missing portions of Maithili sattak works, highlights the institutional importance of textual preservation. The episode shows that an author's standing in literary history may change repeatedly as newly available texts require earlier judgements to be revised.

Janardan Jha 'Jansidan' and the Beginnings of Modern Fiction

The writer discusses at length Ramdev Jha's biographical criticism of Janardan Jha. A reconstruction of the author's life draws upon family testimony, self-description, information from sons and grandsons, and literary works. Arguments for identifying Tarak Vaidhavya as an early modern short story are said to be supported by analysis of plot, characters, dialogue, setting, and conclusion (pp. 193–200).

A term such as 'first story' carries considerable historical weight. Dates, journal issues, other obscure earlier works, and formal features of the texts must therefore be checked. The essay explains Ramdev Jha's arguments, but their claim to priority should not be treated as the final historical verdict without direct examination of other possible early stories.

Sitaram Jha and a Systematic Classification of Poetry

The discussion of Sitaram Jha examines the usefulness of Ramdev Jha's division of poetry into muktak (independent lyrics), descriptive or narrative verse, and extended organized poetic compositions (pp. 201–203). Identifying the appropriate formal category for a work distinguishes literary criticism from general praise of its author. Discussion of Ambcharit, maternal devotion, and devotional poetic feeling adds to the importance of the classification.

Subhadra Jha and Rigorous Standards of Editing

The latter part of this extended essay considers Ramdev Jha's criticism of Subhadra Jha. The judgements on linguistic works, discussions of grammar, collections of Vidyapati's songs, textual emendation, and the purposes and outcomes of editing are mixed. Some publications are regarded as especially important, while the editorial method or objective of others is questioned. Divergent assessments of emendation in Songs of Vidyapati and the usefulness of Vidyapati Git Sangrah (pp. 204–208) show that even criticism written with affection can sustain disagreement.

A Critical Evaluation of the Whole Essay

The significance of this long study lies in its extensive vision. Through Ramdev Jha's research alone, it connects Assam, Nepal, Mithila, medieval drama, poetry, grammar, folklore, editorial scholarship, and literary history. The author frequently compares original quotations, genealogical evidence,

and earlier judgements. The preface's idea of the critic as a bridge is more clearly put into practice here than in many other essays.

The limitations of this expansive discussion deserve equal consideration. The writer endorses many of Ramdev Jha's conclusions, but this single essay does not independently recompare opposing positions, manuscript variants, and modern external research across every disputed question. At some points the lengthy presentation follows the chapters of quoted biographies more closely than it develops comparative theoretical analysis. Nevertheless, the essay is highly useful for understanding 'sajivani criticism' in Maithili: its principal achievement is a confluence of history, textual scholarship, and aesthetic judgement.

14 | Maithili Folk-Ballad Research and Manipadma

Original book, printed pp. 209–224

The Distinctive Genre of the Folk Ballad

In the concluding essay the writer regards the folk ballad as the epic form of folk literature. Singability, expansive narratives, popular heroes, collective memory, social struggles, and the honour accorded to caste-associated folk deities distinguish the form. Even without the uniform metrical organization of the classical epic, the sung rhythms of folk ballads give them a living form. Unlike a fixed written composition, a ballad changes with its singer, period, locality, and listening community (pp. 209–211).

References to the ballads of Salhes, Lorik, Dina-Bhadri, Karikh, Dulara Dayal, Raiya Ranpal, Naika Banijara, Shyamsingh, Gopichand, Ganinath-Govind, Beniram, and other heroes reveal the genre's spread across Mithila's diverse castes and communities. The critic distinguishes a segment of one character's life from a large collective narrative, thereby exploring a possible difference between 'folk ballad' and 'ballad song'. This is a useful beginning to classification, but living performance traditions yield multiple forms of a story; rigid, permanent boundaries should not be imposed on them.

The History of Written Records and Field Investigation

The writer introduces references to folk dance and song in the Varnaratnakara, Grierson's collection of Salhes material, the efforts of later researchers, and the history of publishing various ballads. The difficulties of gathering primary records are especially apparent. When songs from oral traditions are put into writing, much may be lost: a singer's pronunciation, melodic modes, alterations of the story, the social occasion of performance, and listeners' reactions. Consequently, a printed text alone cannot establish the complete meaning of a folk ballad.

The author names contributions by Mahendra Narayan Ram, Phulo Paswan, Rambharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Tarakant Mishra, Vishweshwar Mishra, and other investigators. Some are valued for collecting original texts, others for literary interpretation or classification (pp. 213–218). The account suggests a developing tradition of folk-ballad scholarship. It is an introduction to

different scholars' contributions, not an exhaustive bibliography or a definitive accounting of unauthenticated manuscripts.

The Distinctiveness of Manipadma's Work

The discussion of Manipadma is the essay's decisive stage. According to the author, Manipadma takes the subjects of folk ballads, their characters' worlds, social practices, and distinctive vernacular speech seriously. Using oral material as a foundation, responding to its rasa, and drawing on literary imagination, he creates new works in established literary forms such as narrative fiction, novels, and essays (pp. 219–223). His achievement lies in establishing a dialogue between folk and formally cultivated literature.

This transformation is both a success and a problem. Readers encounter a literary writer's version instead of a singer's orally transmitted performance, thereby widening the hero's popularity. But there is an increased danger that the oral form of the original ballad, regional variants, and the social setting of performance will disappear from view. The critic identifies the tension effectively: Manipadma's literary presentation is valuable, but cannot be substituted for an incontrovertible original text of a folk ballad.

Collection versus Creative Reworking

The essay's sharpest critical question asks whether a researcher preserves the original folk ballad or transforms it through a personal literary method. Both activities are useful, but their aims differ. Collection requires documentation of the place and date of performance, the singer's identity, dialect, sound recording, occasion of singing, narrative variants, and textual differences. Creative reworking gives priority to the author's imagination and aesthetic sense. Forgetting the distinction would allow sources for folk history and works of imaginative literature to replace one another.

While praising Manipadma highly, the critic acknowledges the rarity of original ballad texts and the difficulty of publishing research materials. The final essay is therefore more than a tribute: it proposes a concrete programme for folkloric scholarship. Unless original forms of collected ballads are published, regional variants compared, and linguistic forms preserved, future generations may lose historical evidence of folk life.

Caste-Associated Folk Deities and a Shared Maithili World

The popularity of heroes such as Salhes and Dina-Bhadri is tied to the memories of different caste communities. The writer emphasizes the folk ballad's capacity to construct collective identities. This is an important social fact; nevertheless, conclusions about 'caste harmony' must be accompanied by separate study of unequal social positions, resistance, and conflict. Folk ballads can express not only harmony but also popular memories of resistance to oppression.

Overall Assessment

It is meaningful that this essay closes the book. The opening essay considered the cultural veneration of a river; the last appeals for the

preservation of linguistic and cultural memory surviving in the people's voices. The collection completes its research cycle by moving from historical objects to living oral traditions. The strongest aspect of the evaluation of Manipadma is its distinction between creative talent and the authenticity of primary sources. In folklore research, that distinction remains a useful standard for future studies.

Integrated Critical Conclusions

1. Research Tendencies Shared by the Fourteen Essays

The fourteen essays address different subjects, but share a deep unity: preserving Maithili's literary knowledge and resources and using them to foster social change, linguistic self-respect, and aesthetic awareness. In the first six, preservation and modernity, devotion and social reform, classical metre and contemporary feeling repeatedly confront each other. The prose division uses travel, essays, and the novel as vehicles for a social philosophy of Mithila. The final five essays focus on the structures of modern literary institutions.

From this perspective, calling Chaturdash Sutra merely an occasional collection of reviews would diminish its diverse intellectual purposes. It embodies a specific critical outlook in which literary beauty cannot be detached from society; nor does the development of a language depend solely on the achievements of distinguished poets, but also on journalism, linguistic research, textual editing, schools, libraries, and safeguarding popular knowledge.

2. The Real Tension between Tradition and Innovation

Discussions of hymns to the Ganges and poetry by Snehalata, Pradeep, Mohan, and Jayamant Mishra disclose a strong traditional inheritance. Yet the critic does not simply praise the repetition of tradition. Opposition to dowry in Swayamprabha, satire on mismatched marriage and food taboos in Harimohan Jha, national responsibility in Mohan, uncertainties of an era in Jayamant Mishra, and environmental questions at the end of the essay on Ganga hymns all show that old forms can hold new social meanings. The insistence on judging formal modernity separately from modernity of ideas is one of the collection's major critical achievements.

3. The Strength and Limits of Literary Social Philosophy

Essays on Harimohan Jha, Pradeep, Mayanand Mishra, and Viditji present varied pictures of social problems. The commercialization of marriage, women's unequal status, superstition, caste prejudice, migration, linguistic inferiority, and economic inactivity all emerge in literary texts. The critic frequently advocates social reform. There is, however, a substantial difference between moral instruction and actual institutional transformation. Condemning a problem in poetry and resolving it in society are different acts; literary influence must be evaluated with that distinction in mind.

At times, the critic's affection limits the force of dissent. Assessments of saintly poets or heroes of the language movement devote more attention to

praise than to alternative readings of class, caste, gender, economic power, and institutional failures. Yet much of the evidence he himself supplies is sufficient to generate such questions. The book therefore ought to be read not as an opinion to be accepted unconditionally but as an invitation to extend discussion.

4. 'Sajivani Criticism' and Respect for Sources

The essay on Ramdev Jha becomes the principal image of the book's philosophy of criticism. It brings together works, authors, surroundings, rediscovered older texts, and historical controversies. The linguistic essay on Subhadra Jha and the folk-ballad essay on Manipadma support the principle from different directions: criticism cannot detach literature from its language, records, and living tradition.

Yet the intimacy of biography and the impartiality of research are not always the same. Recollections, family testimony, classical quotations, old manuscripts, and decisions by later historians belong to distinct levels of evidence. Future textual criticism must make these distinctions explicit. The book gains importance wherever it engages with evidence; when it does not examine counterevidence, some avenues of research remain open.

5. Journalism, Language, and Folklore: The Maithili Public Sphere

The journalism of Swadesh, Subhadra Jha's morphology, Jayakant Mishra's literary history, and Manipadma's folklore studies may be regarded as four foundations of a linguistic public sphere, rather than separate minor subjects. Swadesh turns Maithili into a language of daily news; linguistics reveals its distinct structure; literary historiography gives it a memory across time; and folk ballads constitute a storehouse of communities' informal knowledge. This fourfold framework brings forward the collection's deepest intellectual proposition: a language grows rich when, alongside works of literature, it possesses the means to study, communicate, teach, and preserve popular memory.

6. Language, References, and Editorial Examination

The author writes Maithili criticism using Sanskrit-derived scholarly vocabulary, long sentences, an inherited structure of 'explication–analysis–evaluation', and regular quotations from the primary works. This style functions naturally in discussions of classical poetics; clear accounts of plots and examples from ordinary speech make it more accessible in prose and folklore criticism. Occasionally, however, extended lists of names or narrative summaries obscure the main critical question. In those places subheadings, tables of evidence, lists of primary sources, and comparative conclusions would prove more useful.

The publication information for Chaturdash Sutra gives a price of 300 rupees, while the back cover displays 400 rupees. This difference in the printed prices deserves notice in bibliographic records. The available publication details do not establish why it occurred.

7. Practical Directions for Further Research

Several concrete lines of work emerge if Chaturdash Sutra is to be made still more useful for future research. Poetry requires critical editing of the original verses, comparison of textual variants, and systematic metrical analysis. Prose research would benefit from book-by-book examination of the possible relationship between Shyamali and Pathchari and analysis of the narrative construction of all seventeen ullas of Gram-Ganarajya against contemporary social data. Digitally archiving Mayanand Mishra's scattered essays, the original issues of Swadesh, and the rare dramatic songs edited by Ramdev Jha would be especially valuable. Folk-ballad scholarship should preserve audio recordings, locations, performance dates, performers' identities, textual variations, and distinct editions of literary recreations.

These suggestions are presented as research possibilities arising from the reading of the original work, not as claims that the investigations have already been carried out in this study.

Final Assessment

The greatest achievement of Chaturdash Sutra lies in treating Maithili not merely as an emotionally cherished mother tongue but as a vast field of literary genres, social criticism, scientific linguistic inquiry, institutional literary history, and orally transmitted popular knowledge. The writer seeks dialogue, not hostility, between old and new. By discovering social meanings in inherited poetry, recognizing moral conflicts in modern prose fiction, and posing practical questions of linguistic preservation, the collection demonstrates the wide potential of criticism.

Its accomplishments must be considered alongside its critical limitations. Sweeping historical assertions, appreciative judgements on individuals, and indirect references to sources do not all possess the same evidentiary force. In some essays extended narrative summary occupies space that might have been devoted to analysis. Rather than treating the book as a final, unquestionable history, it is fairer to recognize it as a source-rich critical work that poses a wide range of questions.

Overall, Dr Yoganand Jha's collection can be described as an extensive map of Maithili literary research. Read separately, the fourteen essays reveal the significance of individual works; read together, they disclose the internal unity of texts, evidence, society, history, and folk tradition within Maithili language and literature. That unity—and the differences concealed within it —constitute the book's enduring critical value.

Basis of the Book's Study

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03. Jha, Pankaj. A Political History of Literature: Vidyapati and the Fifteenth Century. Oxford University Press, New Delhi, 2019. Print ISBN 9780199489558.

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The name of the publisher of the 2006 edition of Maithili Patrakarita ke Sau Varsh could not be conclusively established from the available publication details; an unverified publisher's name has therefore not been added.

STUDY 02 / NIT NAVAL

Lalita Jha

An Overview of the Work

Dr Lalita Jha's *Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Shabdavali* treats Maithili food practices not merely as a catalogue of dishes or cooking methods, but as a distinct field of linguistic, cultural, literary and historical inquiry. Its principal contribution lies in explaining not only the meanings of numerous words still current in domestic life, but also the objects they designate, their forms, processes, uses, contexts and changing variants. The work thus occupies the intersection of lexicography, the study of folk culture and linguistics.

The present study considers separately the book's introduction to its subject, all twelve chapters, its conclusion and both appendices. The first three chapters establish the historical and social background of food; Chapters Four to Six examine literary evidence; Chapters Seven to Nine explore the vocabulary of actual vernacular usage; and the final three chapters examine phonology, word formation and the system of affixes. This critical account reconstructs the argument of each chapter; it does not reproduce the complete word lists of the original book.

The work's most original feature is its fine-grained lexical differentiation of implements, ingredients and the operations involved in preparing and consuming food. Words such as *kāṡ/kāśā*, *pīṛhī*, *sūp*, *arbā/usinā*, *khakharī* and *niraiṭh* demonstrate how richly Maithili differentiates meanings according to the object, its condition, its purpose and the action involved. In the literary sections, the history of eating utensils, foodstuffs, social relations and proverbs emerges through interwoven strands of evidence.

The critical conclusion is that the preservation of regional food vocabulary requires new documentation of original pronunciation, local variants, contexts of use, speakers' social circumstances and present-day currency. The book is important also because its author pays particular attention to domestic implements, and the names associated with them, that are falling out of use under the pressures of modernity and industrialisation.

Critical Approach

The work's treatment of vocabulary may be understood through three domains of evidence: ancient and modern literature, everyday domestic usage, and the linguistic relationships among sound, form and meaning. The page references provided in the book should be read alongside its literary illustrations and the historical contexts of particular words.

The occurrence of a food name in an ancient text is not the same as proof that the modern dish has survived in precisely the same form. The present

criticism therefore distinguishes the book's claims, the limits of the evidence and the possibilities for further investigation.

Regarding the order of the appendices, it is worth noting that the illustrations appear in Appendix A (pp. 327–331), whereas the list of works consulted appears in Appendix B (p. 332 onwards). The sequence in the book itself, rather than any discrepancy apparent in the contents list, is decisive.

Introduction to the Subject: The Fundamental Research Questions

In her introductory discussion (pp. 27–30), the author regards the word as a fundamental unit of language and distinguishes words of ordinary usage from specialised or technical terms. In matters of food, "specialised" does not refer exclusively to the terminology of external scientific disciplines: it also includes village and household names associated with a particular object, shape, action, taste or occasion. The collection of multiple terms relating to a single subject attests both to linguistic richness and to the texture of social life.

This introduction makes lexical borrowing, semantic change and the disappearance of words central questions. As new implements and food practices enter a changing social world, older names may cease to be used. This does not mean that every new form is intrinsically objectionable; the task of research is to identify the social and practical circumstances in which particular words change. The author's concern is to preserve the cultural knowledge embedded in vernacular vocabulary through this process.

Three fundamental research questions emerge from a critical reading of this introduction: (1) What specific, observable referent does a given specialised word have? (2) How do its form, meaning and use change over time? (3) Where do literary attestations and current popular usage coincide, and where do they differ? All three questions can be applied to the book's twelve chapters.

Chapter One. Traditional Patterns of Indian Food

Relevant pages in the book: 31–39.

Environment and the Foundations of Diet

The author takes geographical environment to be a primary determinant of Indian food. Differences in vegetation, livestock, rivers and water bodies, level agricultural land and plateau terrain create diversity in food resources. Yet food is not simply a question of what nature provides: the social and cultural environment also produces classifications of the "edible" and the "inedible." From the outset, therefore, the chapter calls for geographical conditions and human systems of value to be read together.

Chronological Sources and Their Significance

From the Indus civilisation through Vedic literature, the epics, the Purāṇas, Ayurveda, Sanskrit poetry and drama, and subsequent political and cultural contacts, the author gathers references to foods, drinking practices, and

prescriptions and prohibitions. On pp. 32–38, barley, wheat, rice, sesame, peas, milk and curds, ghee, honey, jaggery, meat and fish (*māch*), fruits and salt are related to literary evidence from particular periods. Texts from different ages should not be taken as evidence of a uniform dietary system. The chapter's value lies in signalling changes across time.

The Difference Between a Name and Its Referent

The occurrence of terms such as *karambha*, *apūpa*, *puroḍāśa*, *dhāna* and *taṇḍula* in older texts establishes that the names were historically attested. Further evidence, however, would be needed to show that dishes now made under the same names were prepared from exactly the same ingredients or by identical methods. Subject to this caution, the chapter provides a broad Indian background for the study of Maithil food.

Prescriptions, Prohibitions and Relations of Power

In matters of diet, distinctions between purity and impurity, permission and prohibition, meat-eating and vegetarianism, social rank and religious belief are presented as historically changing formations. Such descriptions should be understood as perspectives belonging to their respective periods, not as timeless rules of modern nutrition or social ethics.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Jau (barley), cāur (rice), til (sesame), matar (peas)	Historical basis of grain- and agriculture-based diets (p. 32).
Karambha, apūpa, puroḍāśa	Attested food names in Vedic literature (p. 32).
Taṇḍula, sāṭhī dhān	Forms of grain and references specific to a historical period (p. 37).

Critical Appraisal

The method of recovering food names from older literature is valuable, but the social representativeness of literary texts is limited. Practices recorded in elite writings, religious lawbooks or poetry cannot be treated as a complete account of what entire populations actually ate. Independent comparison with archaeology, botanical remains and local history remains a task for future research when constructing chronological conclusions.

Chapter Two. Traditions of Maithil Food

Relevant pages in the book: 40–53.

A Rice-Centred Dietary Structure

The author connects the predominance of paddy cultivation in Mithila, and the region's climate, with its distinctive food culture. The widespread consumption of cooked rice and *chūṛā* (flattened rice), the prestige of *chūṛā-dahī* (flattened rice with curds), pigeon-pea dal, black-gram-based *khichṛī*,

and flatbreads made from finger millet and maize reveal differences in the social distribution and availability of food (pp. 40–42). "Predominant" must not be confused with "exclusive": the book describes a variety of grains, pulses, leafy vegetables, other vegetables, fish (*māch*) and fruits.

Everyday Meals and Cultural Values

Rice with its starchy cooking liquid, flattened rice, roasted grain, greens, pickles, dal and prepared dishes form part of everyday household meals. The importance of fish is also noted in relation to rivers, ponds and other aquatic resources. To consider a meal merely as an assemblage of edible substances is to miss its social meanings: who was served what, on which occasion, which foods signified respect, and which households could afford which kinds of food are all culturally informative questions.

Festivals, Fasts, Life-Cycle Rites and Communal Dining

The author examines food arrangements in the context of weddings, *śrāddha* rites, initiation ceremonies, hospitality and communal meals. Festivals such as Satuani, Jur Shital, Ravi-Shani and Kojagara are associated with particular grains, leftover rice, *sattu*, sun-dried lentil dumplings, *dālipūṛī*, fox nuts and betel (pp. 49–52). Reading these names as an "occasion-marked vocabulary" clarifies the social functions of food terms.

Customary Rules and Social Classification

Pages 43–49 discuss food prohibitions in religious texts, rules about touching food, vessels, food prepared by others, mealtimes, and caste- and *varna*-based prescriptions. Such rules are historical features of textual traditions, not instructions for contemporary society. Keeping this distinction clear enhances the chapter's sociological usefulness.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Bhāt, chūṛā, māṛ	Multiple uses of paddy; several names derived from a single food resource (pp. 40–41).
Rāhaṛi, uṛīd, khesārī	Distinctions among names of pulses and their culinary uses (p. 40).
Satuani, Jur Shital	Relation between seasonal cycles and food rituals (p. 50).
Makhān, pān	Cultural exchange and the occasion of Kojagara (p. 52).

Critical Appraisal

The work records the classification of certain foods as "pure" or "impure," and their association with specific social groups, as elements of inherited belief. Such assertions are best read as descriptions of customary perceptions rather than objective nutritional or ethical judgements. Contemporary regional fieldwork would establish which traditions remain in practice.

Chapter Three. Influences on Maithil Taste and the Changes They Produced

Relevant pages in the book: 54–58.

A Threefold Account of Change

The chapter focuses on three domains: implements, ingredients and the processes of preparing and eating food. In the author's view, industrial development, cultural contact and mechanisation have transformed older culinary arrangements. Page 54 contrasts the *ukkharī–mūsar* (mortar and pestle), *ḍhekī–jāṭ* (traditional pounding and grinding devices), earthen *kohā* and *ghail* vessels, and the low *pīṛhī* seat with the mill, tin drum, metal cooking pot, pressure cooker, jug, plate, chair and table.

The Mechanism of Lexical Replacement

As the use of an object declines, so does the frequency of its distinctive name. With the introduction of new implements, new words—sometimes borrowed from other languages—enter ordinary speech. It is insufficient to describe this process simply as "word loss." One must also examine changes in materials, craftsmanship, fuels, cooking speeds, household labour and social prestige.

The Reconfiguration of Foods and Tastes

The chapter points to increasing flexibility in distinctions between edible and inedible foods, the arrival of new foodstuffs, urban life and changing preferences. As the structures of family, market and employment alter, the social prestige of food vocabulary changes as well. In this way, the chapter establishes the historical rationale for compiling the vernacular lexicon in Chapters Seven to Nine.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Ukkharī–mūsar → mill	Mechanisation and the threatened vocabulary of older processing techniques.
Earthen kohā → metal dekchī	Change in the vessel's material and its name.
Pīṛhī → chair and table	Change in customary seating during meals.
Hearth → stove/electric cooker	Changes in energy sources and cooking techniques.

Critical Appraisal

Change does not proceed exclusively from old to new: in many rural and urban homes, older and newer implements coexist. Future studies should therefore document replacement, coexistence and revival alike. The original

book provides a picture of conditions in 2011; it should not be treated as a universally applicable description of the present.

Chapter Four. Food Practices in Early Maithili Literature

Relevant pages in the book: 59–71.

The Earliest Literary Attestations

The chapter refers to the *Caryāpadas*, verses of the Siddha masters, Prakrit–Apabhraṃśa materials, and Jyotirishwar's *Varṇaratnākara* and *Dhūrtasamāgama*. References on p. 59 to *māṛ* (rice starch), *bhāt* (cooked rice) and *hāṛī* (an earthen pot) establish that vocabulary associated with food occurs not only in modern speech but also in early literary sources. Questions concerning the linguistic classification of these works are complex; nevertheless, the food-related terms appearing in their verses provide useful indications of linguistic history.

The Lexicographical Importance of the *Varṇaratnākara*

The description of a feast in the *Varṇaratnākara* offers a dense account of foods, prepared delicacies, utensils and arrangements for dining (pp. 62–67). The author attempts to interpret many rare terms by consulting both the historical textual context and contemporary Maithili vernacular usage. The mutual dependence of lexicography and textual editing becomes particularly apparent here.

Semantic Interpretation and Caution

Connecting an old word with a similar-sounding modern word may be a reasonable hypothesis, but it is not necessarily a demonstrated etymology. The possible relationship between *amṛtakuṇḍī* and *amiratī*, discussed on p. 66, is a case in point and should remain a hypothesis. Establishing a meaning requires attention to textual variants, context, the nature of the object and intervening historical forms.

The Social World of Food in Early Literature

Terms relating to rice starch, flattened rice, curds, milk, sweets, betel, meals for guests and the decoration of feasts illuminate the history of both language and culture. The presentation of food here serves at once as a pictorial literary embellishment and as a source of information about social practices.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Māṛ, bhāt, hāṛī	Early food-related terms in Siddha literature (p. 59).
Description of a feast in the Varṇaratnākara	A literary assemblage of numerous food terms (pp. 62–67).
Amṛtakuṇḍī / amiratī	Possible semantic development and discussion of etymology (p. 66).

Critical Appraisal

Metaphorical or exaggerated descriptions of feasts in ancient literature should not be treated as direct evidence of typical diets across society. Checking the quoted terms against authoritative editions, manuscript readings and contemporaneous sources would make the chapter's historical conclusions more secure.

Chapter Five. Food Practices in Medieval Maithili Literature

Relevant pages in the book: 72–79.

The Vidyapati Tradition and the Vocabulary of Food

The author investigates food-related vocabulary in the work of Vidyapati, a central writer of the medieval period, and in the tradition associated with him. In *Kīrtilatā*, *Kīrtipatākā* and the lyric *Padāvalī*, food figures not merely as an answer to hunger but as an expression of hospitality, prestige, affection, separation and the norms of social conduct (pp. 72–77). A form such as *subhoan* demonstrates the relationship between an early lexical form and its meaning.

The Meaning of Food Beyond Eating

Figurative language, the wish to offer *khīr* and sugar to a crow, meals offered to guests, curds and ghee obtained from cattle, and references to cultivated grains all reveal the broad literary presence of food. In such instances, *khīr* and *ghṛta* denote food substances, whereas offering someone food—or accepting food under humiliating circumstances—signals a social relationship.

Literary Continuity and Locality

In Vidyapati's language, Sanskrit-derived forms, historically transformed forms and indigenous expressions coexist. Medieval food names can be compared with modern vernacular forms within a defined chronology; however, proof of direct descent for every form requires intermediate evidence.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Subhoan	A word for food attested in medieval literature (p. 72).
Khīr–khāṇḍ	Sweet foods in an affective context (p. 75).
A load of dahī and ghṛta (curds and ghee)	Hospitality and the exchange of gifts (p. 77).
Rāhaṛi, makai	Cultivated foods in a literary setting (p. 78).

Critical Appraisal

This chapter is important for its literary attestations of vocabulary. Yet the differences among manuscript readings, questions of poetic attribution and scholarly disagreements over the periodisation of the language require independent critical examination. Comparing the quoted forms with the relevant actual editions would yield more dependable conclusions.

Chapter Six. Food Practices in Modern Maithili Literature

Relevant pages in the book: 80–164.

The Scope of the Longest Chapter

This is the book's most extensive chapter on literature. The author searches for food-related expressions in five major genres of modern writing: epic poetry, lyric poetry, stories and novels, drama, and essays. Her literary discussion is accompanied by an extensive collection of folk songs, traditional sayings, riddles and proverbs. Given this methodological range across authors and works, it would be inadequate to describe the chapter merely as an anthology of descriptions of dishes.

Epic and Lyric Poetry

The discussion of food practices in epic poetry begins on p. 80, tracing references in modern verse to feasts, guests, fruits, fish, curds, ghee, betel and social celebrations. From p. 90, the examination of lyric poetry brings food into the contexts of morality, famine, humour, everyday life, the seasons and metaphor. Treating food expressions in individual poems merely as dictionary citations, detached from their emotional and literary settings, would diminish the meaning of the poetry.

Stories, Novels, Drama and Essays

From p. 106, the discussion of stories and novels shows how domestic life, scarcity, cooking skills, hospitality, taste and characters' social standing confer meaning upon the language of food. The dramatic examples begin around p. 131; dialogue preserves evidence of living pronunciations and everyday idiom. The consideration of essays from p. 138 onwards reveals links between cultural reflection and memories of fish, mangoes, regional preferences and specific dishes.

The Distinctive Importance of Folk Literature

Pages 141–149 take up folk songs, *barahmāsā* songs of the twelve months, *ḍahakan* songs, dining songs, proverbial sayings and riddles. The *ḍahakan* composed about the in-laws, wedding guests and organisers of a wedding feast reveal the social drama surrounding food. Folk songs preserve memories of communal ceremonial practices in the sequence of seating guests on low *pīṛhī* stools and serving dal and rice, curds and ghee, vegetables and betel.

More Than Two Hundred Proverbs

An ordered collection of proverbs begins on p. 150, with entries numbered beyond 200 appearing on p. 158. The introductory remarks to the original book likewise mention more than two hundred food-related proverbs. This collection extends the meanings of food far beyond "eating and drinking" into metaphors for intelligence, greed, labour, overeating, poverty, social prestige, judgement and conduct. In proverbs, food terms frequently move from primary denotation towards secondary indication and suggestion.

Correlating Literature with Everyday Practice

The breadth of the modern literary record demonstrates that domestic vocabulary constitutes a legitimate literary vehicle for regional knowledge. Yet literary texts, characters' speech and direct social surveys constitute different kinds of evidence. The work supplies substantial initial material for bringing them into dialogue.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Names of different fish	Representation of regional aquatic life in poetry (p. 90).
Tīman, non, tel	The meanings of food terms in domestic dialogue (p. 106).
Ḍahakan	Song traditions associated with communal feasting (p. 146).
Pīṛhī, dal and rice, pān	The ceremonial order of serving food (pp. 147–148).
Proverbs numbered beyond 200	Evidence of the extensive collection of proverbs (p. 158).

Critical Appraisal

The numbers of examples cited from particular genres and periods of modern literature are unlikely to be equal. Lexicographical conclusions would benefit from an electronic index recording genre, author, work, publication year and page references, enabling researchers to test both duplication and actual frequency of use. Renewed regional surveys of proverbs could also establish their current meanings and circulation.

Chapter Seven. Vocabulary of Food Implements in Modern Maithili

Relevant pages in the book: 165–196.

The Principle of Classification

The chapter divides implements into six classes according to their principal material of manufacture: metal, stone, clay, wood, bamboo and grass (p. 165). It then offers detailed distinctions relating to their shape, components, uses,

constituent materials, construction and local names. The method grounds lexical definitions in the actual use of objects.

Names of Metals and Alloys

The metal category includes forms associated with copper (*tām/tāmā*), brass (*pittar/pittari*), bell metal (*kāś/kāśā*) and *kaṃsakūṭ* (pp. 165–174). Such terms denote not only objects but also physical properties and techniques of manufacture. *Bāsan* is a general term for utensils, whereas more specific names may indicate the shape or function of a vessel. Multiple names for one object may also point to regional, dimensional or functional differences.

The Lexical World of the Hearth and Fuel

Pages 175–179 describe the relationships among terms for the hearth, its construction, fuel, the condition of the fire, ash and acts of cooking. If such expressions are arranged in separate lists, the complete form of the technology concerned remains obscure. A network analysis is needed: fuel → construction of the hearth → lighting the fire → controlling heat → cooking food → residues.

Clay, Wood, Bamboo and Grass

The latter part of the chapter explains the earthen *kohā*, *hāṛī*, *ghail* and *kathaut* vessels; the wooden *pīṛhī*, *ḍhekī* and rolling pin; bamboo *sūp* and *ḍagarā* winnowing implements; and other containers. The discussion of variant pronunciations and shapes of the *pīṛhī* on p. 189 is especially significant. Bamboo- and grass-made baskets, *sūp*, *maunī* and storage devices discussed on pp. 192–195 bear witness to traditional craftsmanship.

Standards for Recording Lexical Meanings

For each word in this chapter, it would be possible to record its material, local name, dimensions and shape, maker, purpose, associated activity, ritual occasion and present geographical distribution. Such an entry would amount to a living “ethnographic dictionary,” rather than a mere list of synonyms.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Tām/tāmā, pittar, kāś	Local words for metals and alloys (p. 165).
Cūlhā, jāran, rākh/chāur	Interrelated vocabulary of fuels and the hearth (pp. 175–179).
Kohā, ghail	Shapes and uses of earthen vessels (pp. 181–183).
Pīṛhī/pirhī/baiskī	Pronunciation and functional variations in seating (p. 189).
Sūp, ḍagarā, maunī	Names of objects and crafts based on bamboo and grass (pp. 191–195).

Critical Appraisal

The drawings in Appendix A of the original book are helpful in understanding the implements discussed here, though their number is limited. A digital archive containing high-quality pictures of every implement, location-specific names, measurements and interviews with local craftspeople would be an important next undertaking.

Chapter Eight. Vocabulary of the Basic Materials of Food

Relevant pages in the book: 197–246.

Three Broad Semantic Domains

The author divides food ingredients into "basic," "supplementary" and "special" categories (p. 197). The basic category includes ordinary food grains and locally important roots and tubers. The supplementary category covers ingredients completing a meal, fish, meat, spices and other accompaniments; the special category includes fruits, milk products, honey, sweets, betel and items associated with particular occasions. This is not a chemical or nutritional classification of edible substances. It is organised according to their uses in popular practice.

Fine Distinctions Among Grains, Paddy and Pulses

The treatment of grain on pp. 198–202 includes terms for harvest (*phasīl*), seed (*bīhan*), grain intended for eating (*khaihan*), varieties of paddy, maize cobs, kernels, and the shapes and uses of pulses. Across the life cycle of an agricultural product, its seed, growing plant, crop, stored grain and edible form may each bear distinct names. The lexicographer must therefore connect the stages of cultivation to the stages of cooking.

Roots, Leafy Vegetables and Local Ecology

Words such as *ol*, *alhuā*, *suthnī*, *sārukh* and *cichoṛhī* carry knowledge of local soils, seasons, periods of scarcity and domestic culinary skills (pp. 202–208). The many names for leafy greens and vegetables are similarly significant for the preservation of food biodiversity. The book does not consistently provide scientific botanical equivalents for local names of the same species; that remains a subject for future research.

Fish, Meat and Aquatic Resources

Pages 209–219 are particularly rich in terms denoting the appearance, shape, body parts, flavour and varieties of fish. Fish names are more than biological labels: they also convey information about cooking uses, freshness, smell, seasonal availability and popular preferences. The ecology of Mithila's ponds, rivers and wetlands finds linguistic expression here.

Oils, Spices, Fruits, Honey, Betel and Other Ingredients

Oils and spices are discussed from p. 220, seed-grown (*bijjū/sarahī*) and grafted (*kalmī*) varieties of mango from p. 224, various other fruits thereafter, honey on p. 240, and betel and other specialised substances in the concluding

sections. Terms for mangoes, lemons, jujubes, sugarcane juice and honey express highly nuanced distinctions of local taste. References to intoxicating drinks or substances in the book belong to the study of word meanings; they are not recommendations for consumption.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Phasīl, bīhan, khaihan	Semantic distinctions based on grain production and intended use (p. 198).
Rāhaṛi, uṛīd, kurthī	Regional lexical field of pulses (pp. 199–200).
Cichoṛhī, ol, alhuā	Roots, tubers and popular diets (pp. 202–205).
Many varieties of fish	Morphological and classificatory names for aquatic life (pp. 210–219).
Bijjū/sarahī, kalmī	Distinctions based on how mango trees originate (p. 224).
Madhu (honey)	Meaning of a specialised edible substance (p. 240).

Critical Appraisal

Where an exact scientific name is unavailable, the identity of a plant should not be asserted on the basis of conjecture. The same vernacular name can denote different plants in different villages; reliable identification may require voucher specimens and consultation with local speakers and botanists. Socially defined categories such as “basic” and “special” ingredients may also vary according to income, season and household.

Chapter Nine. Vocabulary of the Processes and Activities of Food

Relevant pages in the book: 247–281.

A Dictionary of Processes, Not Merely Objects

This chapter makes all the operations by which naturally obtained materials are turned into food and consumed part of the vocabulary under investigation. The author proposes five groups: (1) terms relating to grain, (2) those relating to cooked dishes, (3) those relating to milk, (4) those relating to sweets and prepared delicacies, and (5) those relating to eating (p. 247). The distinctive feature of this method is its recognition that a single general activity can produce different results with distinct names.

The Sequence of Operations from Paddy to Food

The use of words such as *dhān*, *bhussā*, *cāur*, *khakharī/khakhaṛā*, *arbā* and *usinā* on pp. 247–253 identifies both the condition of the material and the process it undergoes. The chapter discusses numerous names for such stages as removing the outer husk of paddy, parboiling and drying rice, cleaning rice

and cooking it into a meal. A term such as *adhasijjhū* denotes food that has been only partially cooked.

The Processual Meanings of Dishes and Sweets

Pages 254–271 describe in detail the sequences of preparation, mixing, heating, shaping, preparing batter, cooking and making syrup for foods such as dal, greens, vegetables, *baṛī*, *piḍukiyā* and *jilebī*. On p. 266, *jilebī* is explained through the combination "method of preparation + form + final cooking." Such a definition is far more useful than a purely formal dictionary synonym.

Serving, Eating, the Condition of Food and Social Acts

Pages 272–277 connect the acts of mixing food, eating, and terms such as *jūṭh/aiṇṭh*, *niraiṭh*, *not-bijho* and *bhojanī* to the practical and social meanings of meals. The distinction between *aiṇṭh* and *niraiṭh* identifies locally recognised categories of food's condition after use and of ritual or social purity. Such categories should be understood descriptively and in context.

Taste, Smell and Sensory Experience

The final pages contain words describing flavours, the smell of burning, the effects of metal vessels, the pungency of chillies and bodily responses (pp. 277–281). Examples such as *pitarāini* and *susuāyab* reveal an experiential precision in the language. Sound symbolism, sensation and verbal form deserve integrated study within this semantic domain.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Arbā, usinā	Different processes for turning paddy into rice (pp. 247–248).
Bhussā, khakharī, khuddī	By-products of processing and conditions of grain (pp. 247–250).
Adhasijjhū	A specific state of incomplete cooking (p. 252).
Jilebī, cāsnī	A process-based definition of a sweet dish (p. 266).
Aiṇṭh, niraiṭh	Differentiated states following the consumption of food (p. 273).
Susuāyab	A bodily and vocal reaction to pungent taste (p. 279).

Critical Appraisal

A modern dictionary of food should record the relationships among "action–implement–object–result" in a single entry. For example, separating the nouns denoting successive states of rice, the verbs describing its cooking and adjectives expressing its taste would obscure their actual semantic connections. Translating the vocabulary of this chapter into process maps would constitute a substantial extension of its research.

Chapter Ten. Phonological Analysis of Maithili Food Vocabulary

Relevant pages in the book: 282–289.

From Everyday Usage to the Sound System

After assembling a substantial vocabulary, the author examines patterns of vowels and consonants. Examples of short, long and extra-short vowel quantities, nasalisation, vowel combinations and consonant clusters in the pronunciation of food-related terms are collected on pp. 282–286. The chapter shows that food vocabulary can provide rich material for investigating the general phonological structure of a language.

Variation in Sound and Form

Forms such as *ghail–ghailcī* and *kathaut–kathautiyā* reveal the connections among pronunciation, word formation and differences of meaning. Pages 287–289 propose possible chains of sound change leading from Sanskrit and Prakrit to modern forms—for example, from *apūpa* to *pūā/pū* and from *śūrpa* to *sūp*. These examples provide material for arguments in historical linguistics, but each proposed chain must be checked against sound laws and attested intermediate forms before it can be accepted.

Spelling and Actual Pronunciation

The written form of a word, its regional pronunciation and an idealised etymological form may differ considerably. To replace the spoken pronunciation of a remembered vernacular word automatically with a Sanskritised spelling would therefore obstruct understanding of the lexical heritage.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Ghail/ghailcī	Sound and word forms associated with shape and derivation (p. 282).
Apūpa → pūā/pū	Possible historical development of a word form (p. 287).
Śūrpa → sūp	An instance of consonant-cluster simplification (p. 288).
Mṛtti → māṭi	Historical context and phonological change (p. 289).

Critical Appraisal

The chapter does not consistently use a standard international system of phonetic transcription. Future studies should supply audio recordings, International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA) transcriptions, the region of use, speakers' ages and social circumstances. Such documentation would help distinguish pronunciation variants from genuinely separate words.

Chapter Eleven. Lexical Analysis

Relevant pages in the book: 290–309.

Conventional, Compositional and Specialised Compounds

From p. 290 onwards, the author classifies words by derivational criteria as *rūṛha* (conventional or lexicalised), *yaugika* (compositionally formed) and *yogarūṛha* (compounds with specialised established meanings). The ordinary meanings of *ghī*, *jau*, *dahī* and *thārī*, for example, cannot be derived from the analysis of their constituent elements; they illustrate the conventional category. *Dāli* + *pūṛī* → *dalipūṛī* and *dāli* + *sāg* → *dalisaggā* illustrate transparent compounding. A form such as *bhatkhai* may have a particular conventional meaning distinct from the ordinary sum of its component senses.

Word Origins and Language Contact

Pages 298–301 discuss inherited, Sanskrit-borrowed (*tatsama*), historically evolved (*tadbhava*), indigenous (*deśaja*) and borrowed words. Alongside Maithili's historically developed forms, its food vocabulary includes borrowings from other languages. Yet the identification of a source language merely because a word sounds foreign requires the support of reliable historical dictionaries and early textual attestations.

Parts of Speech, Gender, Number and Inflection

Pages 302–305 provide scattered examples of nouns, adjectives, verbs, diminutive formations, gender and related grammatical patterns. Forms such as *thār–thārī* and *poṭhā–poṭhī*, considered together with linguistic structures, demonstrate that many rural terms belong to families of related derivations.

Regional Variation, Spelling and Semantic Change

Pages 305–308 consider synonyms, differences of pronunciation, orthographic variants, and the possibilities of semantic narrowing and extension. The specialised meaning of *guṇḍā* and the use of *mūṛā* to mean the head of a fish (p. 308) illustrate semantic change. Such claims should be supported by evidence dated to identifiable periods.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Ghī, jau, dahī, thārī	Examples of conventional lexical items (p. 290).
Dalipūṛī, dalisaggā	Transparent, compound-like formations (p. 292).
Bhatkhai	An example of specialised lexicalised-compound meaning (p. 296).
Thār–thārī, poṭhā–poṭhī	Morphological relationships and distinctions of meaning (p. 305).

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Guṇḍā, mūṛā	Examples of semantic narrowing (p. 308).

Critical Appraisal

In analysing words as "monosyllabic," "disyllabic" and so forth, syllables, written letters and phonemic counts are not interchangeable; the procedure needs to be specified. At the boundaries of the conventional–compositional–lexicalised-compound classification, the same word may function differently in different regions. Each entry should therefore be supported by an example sentence and testimony from regional speakers.

Chapter Twelve. Prefixes and Suffixes

Relevant pages in the book: 310–322.

The Limited Role of Prefixes

The author considers prefixes relatively infrequent in derived food-related vocabulary. Forms such as *kubhojan*, *subhojan* and *susvādu*, involving *ku-* and *su-*, are given as examples, while the Persian-derived *be-* is also discussed (p. 310). Words such as *niraiṭh* draw particular attention to combinations of a prefix-like element with a local stem.

The Richness of Primary and Secondary Derivational Suffixes

Pages 311–319 demonstrate a range of nominal, adjectival and participial formations using suffixes such as *-ani*, *-iā*, *-ā*, *-ī*, *-uā* and *-āh*. A suffix is not merely an addition to a stem: it can involve sound change and distinguish diminutives, relational meanings, places, associations or particular qualities. Forms such as *kuṭiā*, *kathautiyā*, *chāčhiyā*, *bhorāh* and *maṭiāh* exemplify morphological productivity.

The Suffix *-āin* and the Semantics of Smell and Taste

In the introductory material to the original book, Dr Shriramdev Jha particularly discusses possible meanings of the suffix *-āin* (preliminary pp. 18–19). The semantic relationships between the feminine-denoting *-āin* of general usage and terms for taste and odour such as *bisāin*, *ḍaṛhāin* and *ichāin* are complex. Their historical origins and semantic development should be identified as hypotheses rather than established facts.

Complex Suffix Sequences and the Limits of the Analysis

On pp. 320–322, the author acknowledges that the origins of suffixes, their successive combination, uncertain meanings and problems of standardisation remain open research questions. A complex formation such as *amilgar* indicates that a single uniform rule of suffixation cannot be applied to all words. The willingness to acknowledge these limits is a mark of the work's serious research orientation.

Lexical Evidence from the Text

Original word or expression	Meaning and context
Ku-, su-	Prefixation involving elements of Sanskrit origin (p. 310).
Niraiṭh	A local stem and a prefix-like structure (p. 310).
Kuṭiā, chāčhiyā	Nominal derivation by suffixation (pp. 311–313).
Bhorāh, maṭiāh	Suffixes indicating a property or association (p. 316).
Bisāin, ḍaṛhāin	Debate in the introduction about terms denoting smell (pp. 18–19).
Amilgar	An example of successive suffixation (p. 326).

Critical Appraisal

Resemblance in outward form is not sufficient to establish that a word-final element is a suffix. Reliable analysis requires examining productivity, its occurrence in several independent forms, consistency of meaning, chronology and regular sound change. The chapter thus provides a set of questions for future morphological research.

Conclusion: A Critical Re-reading

In the conclusion to the original book (pp. 323–326), the author shows how extensive the domain of food vocabulary is in both literature and spoken language. The historical context of Indian traditions, distinctive local features of Maithil food, encounters between traditional and modern implements, literary attestations, changing phonological forms, contact between indigenous and borrowed words, and the complexities of suffixation are brought together once more. This concluding synthesis raises the book beyond a mere "list of foods" and establishes it as a study of linguistic and cultural history.

The principal judgement of the present critical study is that the work's essential material lies in the relationships among "object–action–name–use–context." The name of an object cannot be separated from its cultural use, nor can a word's etymology be divorced from attested pronunciation. On this understanding, the daily preparation and consumption of food in the household become indispensable materials for linguistic inquiry.

The original work is exceptionally rich in its collection of words. To transform it into a modern, searchable lexical database, however, each entry would need to register the form of the word, its meaning, geographical distribution, image of the referent, source page, attested example, pronunciation, part of speech, synonyms, semantic relations and current

status. This proposal is not a depreciation of the work, but a programme for developing its achievements into a new phase of research.

A Study of the Appendices

Appendix A: Drawings of Selected Implements (pp. 327–331)

The original text offers detailed explanations of implements made from metal, clay, wood and bamboo; the appendix includes line drawings to help readers visualise them. The drawings are valuable because they make meanings associated with the shapes of objects immediately comprehensible. They are selected supplementary material, not a complete inventory. A future illustrated dictionary should provide an independent entry, image, dimensions and variant names for every implement.

Appendix B: List of Works Consulted (p. 332 onwards)

The book concludes with an extensive list of Sanskrit, Prakrit, Maithili, linguistic and other reference works. This establishes that the vocabulary is not drawn exclusively from oral experience: the author also attempts to compare it with literary and historical evidence. The list is a useful starting point for researchers, although the publication details of some older editions may require renewed verification against modern bibliographic standards.

Linguistic and Cultural Conclusions

1. Food Vocabulary Is an Archive of Social Memory

Names of objects such as the *sūp*, *jāt* and *pīṛhī* are inseparable from the histories of their makers, their use and domestic labour. When an implement falls out of use, the specialised terms for its parts and for the actions associated with it may be among the first to be forgotten.

2. Food Traditions Are Not Uniform

Even within rice-growing Mithila, traditions encompass different grains, greens, pulses, fish, roots, tubers and particular fruits and flowers. "Maithil food" is a useful cultural designation, but it must leave room for differences of season, family, economic position, occupation, region and ritual occasion.

3. Verbs Denoting Processes Are Particularly Vulnerable

Verbs such as *chāṭab*, *phaṭakab*, *paiñcab*, *rānhab*, *ulabab*, *auṇṭab* and *sānab* change together with older technologies. Collecting only the names of ingredients would recover merely half the history of the language of food.

4. Literature Provides Evidence of Meaning, Not Complete Statistics of Practice

Chapters Four to Six present multilayered examples from ancient, medieval and modern literature. These indicate historical sequences; nevertheless, an individual literary reference cannot stand for the total distribution of food across an entire society.

5. Sound, Words and Affixes Must Not Be Isolated from One Another

In forms such as *ghail–ghailcī*, *thār–thārī* and *kathaut–kathautiyā*, sound, word form, the size or shape of the object, and meaning are mutually dependent. All four levels should be recorded in lexical entries.

6. Unsubstantiated Normalisation of Original Forms Causes Information Loss

Transforming an indigenous word into Sanskritised orthography in the name of "correction" can erase its historical sound patterns and regional identity. The proper scholarly practice is to respect the forms followed by the author while identifying demonstrable printing errors and uncertain readings in critical notes.

Principal Lexical Domains: A Comparative Table

Lexical domain	Examples from the original book	Semantic context
Grains	Dhān, cāur, arbā, usinā, khuddī, māṛ	Names of successive stages from production to consumption
Pulses	Rāhaṛi, uṛīd, kurthī, masurī	Use and regional classification
Roots and tubers	Ol, cichoṛhī, alhuā, suthnī	Seasons, ecology and popular diet
Metal vessels	Tām, pittar, kāś, kaṃsakūṭ	Materials and characteristics of manufacture
Earthen vessels	Kohā, ghail, hāṛī	Shape, storage and cooking
Bamboo and grass	Sūp, ḍagarā, maunī	Craftsmanship, winnowing and storage
Eating practices	Sānab, khāyab, aiṇṭh, niraiṭh	Action, result and customary conduct
Taste and smell	Khaṭmadhur, pitarāini, ḍaṛhāin	Experience-specific semantic distinctions
Word formation	Dalipūṛī, kathautiyā, maṭiāh	Compounding, suffixation and parts of speech

Directions for Future Research

First stage—reliable retranscription of the original vocabulary. For each entry, separately record the original printed page, actual spelling, sentence context, part of speech and editorial determination of the reading. Because a single page may contain numerous local synonyms and semantic distinctions, terms should not automatically be reduced to one standardised form.

Second stage—field research. Audio recordings should be made in Maithili-speaking villages and households in Darbhanga, Madhubani, Samastipur, Sitamarhi, Saharsa, Supaul and the Maithili-speaking areas of Nepal, alongside direct observation of objects and cooking activities. Regional representativeness will depend on sampling method and sample size. With speakers' consent, sounds, photographs, production processes and variant names should be preserved.

Third stage—thematic mapping. Prepare process diagrams and digital semantic networks such as "paddy → removing the husk → rice → cooked rice → serving → *jūṭh/niraiṭh*" or "bamboo → splitting → strips → *sūp/ḍagarā* → winnowing grain." Such maps would make the relationships among implements, materials and actions explicit.

Fourth stage—verification of literary evidence. Quotations from the *Caryāpadas*, *Varṇaratnākara*, Vidyapati, modern stories and poetry, drama and folk songs should be checked again against their original editions. A reference archive should record work, editor, publication year and page.

Fifth stage—separating uncertain etymologies. Attested sequences of forms, conjectural derivations, oral traditions and similarities of meaning should be assigned distinct evidential labels. This would make the research open to review and revision.

Sixth stage—preservation of living usage. Oral descriptions provided by elderly speakers, people skilled in domestic cookery and local artisans should be compared with younger generations' current vocabulary, so that frequently used, partially current and endangered terms can be distinguished.

Overall Assessment

The twelve chapters of *Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Shabdavali* advance a unified argument. The opening historical discussion shows that food reflects both natural resources and social ideas. The literary chapters demonstrate that words associated with food permeate Maithili's literary life. The vernacular-lexicographical chapters establish the existence of extraordinarily fine lexical distinctions among implements, materials and activities. The final three chapters demonstrate that this vocabulary also forms fundamental material for phonological and morphological study.

The book's central achievement, then, is not the "number of food-related words" it records, but its conception of food as an extensive semantic field and its integration of linguistic classification, social contexts and etymological complexities into a sustained piece of research. An illustrated, sound-enabled and geographically tagged digital dictionary based on the book could become an exceptionally useful means of preserving Maithili's vernacular linguistic heritage.

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STUDY 03 / NIT NAVAL

Kamla Chaudhary

Preface

Nit Naval Kamla Chaudhary is an attempt to examine the presence of a single creative personality across several literary genres. Kamla Chaudhary's creative and scholarly interests assume distinct forms in fiction, translation and cultural lexicography. Any study of this work must preserve the generic distinctions between original writing, translated literature and works of terminology.

The first chapter presents an extended critique of Kamla Chaudhary's Maithili translation of Ashapurna Devi's narrative Monak Pauti, examining Shashitara's self-determination, familial claims of ownership and linguistic transformation. In bringing together the two strands of the enquiry, twelve consecutive textual sections of the narrative and seventy-five comparative points concerning the Bengali–Maithili contexts have been incorporated in a single sequence. Similarity of narrative content has not been equated with word-for-word correspondence; the question of the original Bengali title has likewise been examined with due caution.

The second chapter reads all fourteen stories of Samay-Sanket in their original order. The third considers the cultural and linguistic significance of the twelve chapters, conclusion and appendices of Maithilīk Vesh-Bhūshā-Prasādhan Sambandhī Shabdāvalī (A Maithili Vocabulary of Dress, Costume and Adornment). Across these three studies, the interrelationships between individual and society, language and cultural memory, and literature and lived experience form a connecting thread.

The volume concludes with an integrated assessment and a book-centred bibliography. Where the publisher's details of a primary work could not be established, this uncertainty has been explicitly retained; no conjectural publication information has been supplied.

Chapter 1: Monak Pauti — Translation, Narrative and Comparative Criticism

Primary work: Ashapurna Devi, Monak Pauti; Maithili translation by Kamla Chaudhary. Pallavi Prakashan, Berma/Nirmali, 2022. ISBN 978-93-93135-12-4.

Introduction to the Work and Critical Framework

Monak Pauti is Kamla Chaudhary's Maithili translation of the novella Moner Jhanpi by the Bengali writer Ashapurna Devi. Taking the entire available Maithili edition as its basis, this study examines Shashitara's character, the social regulation of widowhood, property rights, the family's intermingled self-interest and affection, and the possibility of emotional intimacy in later life. Its central proposition is that the translated narrative

does more than carry the subject matter of Bengali literature into Maithili: through the social cadence, forms of address, dialogue and cultural resonances of the target language, it also creates an opportunity to reconsider the independent existence of a woman.

The method operates on two levels. At the first, the sequence of events, the characters' voices and the development of meaning are examined without omitting any portion of the printed Maithili text, following its pagination (pp. 7–89). At the second, the analytical instruments of translation studies—Nida's formal and dynamic equivalence, Venuti's domestication and foreignisation, syntactic shifts, the transfer of culturally specific terms and the translator's visibility—are applied to textual examples.

The publication details of the Maithili book identify the original Bengali title as Moner Jhanpi. A Bengali text entitled Sonar Kouto ('The Golden Box'; Bengali: সোনার কৌটো) also displays close affinities with its plot. The publishing history of the printed Bengali editions would be important in establishing the historical relationship between these different titles; conjecture is not treated as evidence here.

Narrative Structure and Textual Units of Analysis

The novella proceeds as a continuous narrative: from pages 7 to 89, the original book contains neither separately numbered chapters nor sections bearing fixed titles. For the purposes of this study, twelve interpretative 'textual units' have been devised. These constitute an editorial classification, not chapters of the original work. Each unit covers consecutive pages, and no narrative page has been omitted.

Textual unit	Pages of Maithili edition	Principal narrative concern
1	7–13	Shashitara's situation; widowhood, family and memory
2	14–20	Home, social recognition, everyday life and the public gaze
3	21–27	Religion, philanthropy, service and a woman's autonomy
4	28–34	Dialogue, Ajit and the emerging question of property
5	35–41	Old age, relationships and conventional norms
6	42–49	Temple, land, nephew's family and Master Ramesh
7	50–56	Rajbala's statements; intensifying family self-interest

Textual unit	Pages of Maithili edition	Principal narrative concern
8	57–63	Ramesh's dialogue, new possibilities and suspicion
9	64–70	Use of land, sale and purchase, and self-determination
10	71–77	Jivesh's proposal, negotiation and new construction
11	78–84	Change, the meaning of "hamar", and a rethinking of belonging
12	85–89	Final intimacy, conventions of age and an open ending

A Reading of the Entire Narrative in Twelve Textual Units

Textual Unit 1: Character and Widowhood at the Beginning (pp. 7–13)

The opening pages introduce Shashitara's life not through a flat biographical account but through a narrative shaped by memory and questioning. The setting of Phulpur and the Chattopadhyay family, her past marriage, her husband's death and her relationship with her natal home together constitute the life of a woman who is a widow in society's eyes and an enduring centre of responsibility within the family. From the outset, society's habitual assessment of her comes into conflict with her own point of view.

Shashitara serves within the household, helps others with their tasks and conceals her sorrow behind laughter; she is therefore more than an object of pity. The people around her address her as 'Pisi' or by other respectful kinship terms. This network of relationships offers support on one side while drawing boundaries around her personal rights on the other. Details of her marital past on pages 8–9 and everyday conversations on pages 10–13 gradually disclose the pain of her solitary existence.

The critical significance of this section lies in the narrative's challenge, from its very beginning, to the fixed social identity of the 'widow' through the many dimensions of an individual human life. Familial and religious symbols evoke not only bereavement but also the hunger for human attachment. From the first pages, the translator uses the language of domestic life, touches of gentle humour and brief exchanges to bring the reader close to the protagonist.

Textual Unit 2: Household Life, Social Opinion and the Spirit of Service (pp. 14–20)

On pages 14–16, descriptions of everyday living, Shashitara's attentiveness to her own decisions and expressions of familial concern become more prominent. On one side stands the family's respectability; on the other,

Shashitara's will. Society expects her service but shows comparatively little inclination to ask what she herself desires. As a result of this discrepancy, even her silence becomes meaningful.

Flowers, worship, children and interactions with neighbours are significant on pages 16–18. The narrative reveals the family's dependence on Shashitara without making any explicit declaration. To regard the scene of gathering flowers merely as a domestic chore would be to miss half its meaning: the flowers signify personal attachment, worship, and affection both received and withheld. On pages 19–20, conversations involving neighbours, relatives and a teacher prepare the social setting for subsequent developments.

The exchanges are enlivened by the immediacy of such questions as 'Ki?' ('What?'), 'Kiek?' ('Why?') and 'Ahan?' ('You?'). Linguistic naturalness can become a form of ethical resistance. Rather than through sweeping ideological pronouncements, the story reveals a woman's experience to the reader through affection, laughter and the questions of ordinary life.

Textual Unit 3: Religion, Philanthropy and Independence (pp. 21–27)

On pages 21–23, discussions of schooling, service, the suffering of others, daily work from morning to evening, and the needs of relatives strengthen the action-oriented dimension of Shashitara's character. Her religious or moral disposition is not restricted to ritual observance; it is connected to the pain of living human beings. Thus, flowers offered in worship and care given to the sick are presented not as opposites but as expressions of different human needs.

On pages 24–25, concern for health and questions of material means reveal the protagonist's self-respect. Those whom she looks after are accustomed to regarding her simply as a boundless source of maternal affection; yet her own desires, body and time also possess value for Shashitara. On pages 26–27, familial conversations disclose the distinction between affection and self-interest.

In this passage, the story does not assume that love must automatically follow from duty. Service ought to be a matter of willing consent, not an entitlement imposed by a coercive society: this idea gradually takes shape. The translator conveys the subtle sentiment through living dialogue rather than the rigid voice of moral instruction.

Textual Unit 4: The Emergence of the Question of Inheritance (pp. 28–34)

Pages 28–29 contain reasoned questions and answers alongside feelings of human affection, trust and devotion. On pages 30–31, issues of lived experience, insecurity over property and social usefulness emerge. Shashitara is not simply an elderly woman absorbed in recollection; she engages with work, ideas and the realities of her circumstances.

On pages 32–34, Ajit's name, the improvement of the house or changing needs, and the question of land gradually assume importance in the plot. At this point the narrative moves from the emotional life of the household

towards economic and legal interests. The paradox of not being regarded as at home in one's own home, and the possibility of deciding what to do with one's own share, bring out what women's rights mean in practice.

Read from the perspective of feminist criticism, 'property' here is not merely wealth but a measure of the recognition of a woman's personhood and her right to decide. Shashitara's affection constitutes no written undertaking to surrender herself economically to anyone.

Textual Unit 5: Personal Old Age versus Socially Imposed Old Age (pp. 35–41)

In her exchanges with family members and acquaintances on pages 35–37, Shashitara repeatedly returns to the fact that an older person's desires do not die. A sense of belonging in home and neighbourhood, past acts of service and present personal aspirations coexist in a single character. In this story, 'old age' is not simply a bodily condition; it also becomes a code of conduct imposed by society.

On pages 38–39, discussions of socioeconomic change, a new house, land and the family's interests advance. On pages 40–41, Shashitara's account of herself collides with the conduct of others. The question ceases to be merely what she wants; it becomes whether society is prepared to acknowledge what she wants.

The prose in this passage is marked by subtle irony. People praise 'Bari Pisi' for her service and sacrifice, yet at the moment of decision they tend to treat her judgment as though it were that of a child. This makes the contradictions within the character intelligible to the reader.

Textual Unit 6: Land, the Temple and the Arrival of Master Ramesh (pp. 42–49)

On pages 42–44, conversations involving Shashitara's grandchildren, the household and religious practices increase the importance of land and material resources. References to the temple establish another plane of faith and social recognition in her life. On pages 44–45, the expectations of her nephew's family and the question of her share in her marital family's property point towards the conflict to come.

Master Ramesh's presence becomes decisive from page 45 onwards. He is not merely the stereotypical 'man who provides the solution': his conversations with Shashitara raise questions of humanity, trust and an independent life. On pages 48–49, humorous exchanges about outward appearance, beauty and old age reveal an emerging intimacy.

In this section, the translator differentiates the voices of two socially distinct characters through respectful forms of address, short sentences, teasing remarks and incisive questions. The narrative offers an unusual example of intellectual discussion conducted in the language of ordinary domestic conversation.

Textual Unit 7: Rajbala's Opposition and the Ethics of a 'Share' (pp. 50–56)

On pages 50–52, Rajbala's statements, Master Ramesh's intervention and the tension in relationships give the plot a new turn. There are competing accounts of whose 'share' it is, who has rendered 'service' and who owes a 'duty'. Shashitara's economic concerns and human aspirations are not reduced to a simple opposition.

On pages 53–55, a question arises within the family: if land is an ancestral legacy, whose opinion should determine its use or sale? To interpret Rajbala's anxieties solely as a villain's greed would be inadequate. The family's economic future, customary assumptions of collective ownership and the unfamiliarity of property being held in a woman's name are also at work. Yet, within this complex arrangement, Shashitara's personal right of ownership is being effaced.

On pages 55–56, Ramesh's questions expose this inequality without aggression. Recalling a person's past service does not thereby extinguish her capacity to decide. Herein lies the story's ethical force: affection, if it does not rest on free choice, can become a subtle form of possession.

Textual Unit 8: Ramesh's Humane Outlook and Reserve (pp. 57–63)

Through Master Ramesh's repeated appearances on pages 57–60, an increasingly intimate dialogue develops between Shashitara's past and present. References to secondary characters, including Rajni, broaden the social world of the story. Shashitara's spontaneous laughter, economy of speech and silence in response to certain questions suggest that many layers of experience remain unspoken within her.

On pages 61–63, the family's suspicions, public gossip and the possibility of a new relationship move together. Ramesh shares with Shashitara not only the language of duty but also that of heartfelt affection. Social surveillance of their closeness, however, remains undiminished: even the natural contact between a widowed woman and a mature man may be construed as a violation of propriety.

The rhythm of their conversations gives this reserve a living presence. Without any explicit declaration of romantic love, companionship, advice, silence, care and the wish to meet again acquire a deepening significance. This subtlety distinguishes the narrative from a conventional love story.

Textual Unit 9: The Decision about Land and Self-Respect (pp. 64–70)

On pages 64–66, the conflict becomes clearer amid Ajit's involvement, the price of land, the expectations of acquaintances and plans to build a house. On page 66, Shashitara speaks of her own share; to understand this statement as mere anger would be mistaken. It is the direct expression of self-respect after a long period of dependence.

On pages 67–69, various possibilities arise for selling the land or putting it to her own use. Shashitara views her financial decision in connection with a

moral or social purpose. Family members perceive a loss to themselves in this decision, thereby exposing their underlying self-interest.

By page 70, the recurrence of events and the tension of debate move towards a climax. The translator retains concrete terms such as ‘हमर’ (hamar, 'mine'), ‘हिस्सा’ (hissa, 'share'), ‘जमीन’ (jamin, 'land') and ‘मकान’ (makan, 'house') in the language of the narrative. Through this material vocabulary, a woman's right becomes a real civic question rather than an emotional demand.

Textual Unit 10: Jivesh's Questions and New Construction (pp. 71–77)

On pages 71–73, episodes involving Jivesh and property lend the economic proposal concrete form. The desire to sell the land, prospective buyers, prices, future security and familial self-interest are all present at once. Shashitara's idea of changing the appearance of the old house gives material expression to the broader thought that a new beginning remains possible even in the last stage of life.

On pages 74–75, Ajit's arguments, Shashitara's firmness and the story's social irony emerge together. Ajit sees the land's financial value; Shashitara seeks, through it, to determine the meaning of her own existence and future. Neither party can simply be labelled entirely 'good' or 'evil'. Nevertheless, the woman's independent consent remains the ethical criterion.

On pages 76–77, scenes of the house, work, marketplace and construction provide a material foundation for otherwise invisible emotions. The new house is more than a set of walls: it embodies recognition of Shashitara's wishes and her aspiration for security of residence in the future.

Textual Unit 11: A New Meaning of Belonging (pp. 78–84)

On pages 78–79, Shashitara's busy activity and growing trust in Master Ramesh reveal a new energy in her life. The ordinary pronoun ‘हमर’ (hamar, 'mine' or 'my') acquires particular gravity here. Family is not defined by blood ties alone; it is also created through mutual respect, affection and conduct. The structure of this ethical proposition becomes clear.

On pages 80–82, lonely old age, emotional closeness and the possibility of a changed life occupy the narrative's centre. Social embarrassment, memories of the past and a new orientation towards the future coexist within Shashitara. The reader recognises that the wish to live independently and the desire for another person's affection need not be contradictory.

On pages 83–84, social bitterness, the behaviour of another household and the relationships within her nephew's family are viewed in a new light. Without yet declaring any definitive 'solution', Shashitara recovers from within herself the right to accept or reject what is offered.

Textual Unit 12: On the Eve of the Final Decision and the Opening of Love (pp. 85–89)

On pages 85–86, a family invitation, respect for an elderly woman and the possibility of a relationship carry the story towards its climax. An unexpected

intimacy enters Master Ramesh's voice, while embarrassment, judgment, tenderness and apprehension mingle within Shashitara. The distance between social convention and personal happiness becomes the final form of the narrative's underlying tension.

On page 87, the question of how human relationships acquire meaning beyond the boundaries of home, family and blood ties is handled with great subtlety. On pages 88–89, the years lodged in Shashitara's memory, an awareness of mortality and new affection come face to face. Brief exchanges between Master Ramesh and Shashitara on the final page release 'love' from the arithmetic of age. Rather than sentimental excess, they suggest shared responsibility and a new meaning of life.

To describe the ending either as the complete defeat of social convention or as the culmination in marriage would be to draw conclusions beyond the text. A more persuasive reading is that the novella opens the door of affection that had closed within Shashitara, leaving the reader with an unresolved but dignified possibility.

Characterisation and Moral Conflict

Shashitara: An Independent Mind within a Life of Service

Shashitara is the narrative's central character. Her characterisation has three layers: widowhood and familial standing in the past; service, labour and social respect in the present; and rights, affection and decision-making in the future. Her competence in domestic work does not constitute the whole of her consciousness. When the question of land arises, her independence of mind becomes evident alongside her economic rights. In this sense, the protagonist does not consider independence synonymous with loneliness.

Rajbala: The Complexity of Domestic Conduct and Self-Interest

At different moments Rajbala's speech expresses affection, a claim to authority or fear of loss to her relatives. To cast her as an unvarying villain would be to miss the social reality. Her conduct reveals the process by which decisions about property belonging to a woman are brought under collective family control. She also represents expectations learned from the social order.

Master Ramesh: A Test of Sympathy and Equality

Master Ramesh's function is not simply to settle disputes. He asks questions, listens, offers suggestions and respects the possibility of human relationships. Critical caution is nevertheless necessary: Shashitara's emancipation must not be construed as an outcome of Ramesh's benevolence alone. The story has already established her strength of mind and resourcefulness. Ramesh accompanies the recognition of that autonomy; he does not originate it.

Ajit, Jivesh and the Wider Circle of Relatives

Questions of property and residence arise repeatedly in relation to Ajit; through Jivesh's economic or familial circumstances, dealings in land become concrete. Such characters give voice to the narrative's 'other side'. Neighbours,

acquaintances, pupils and other family members construct Shashitara's public image. The tension between the pressure exerted by that image and her personal experience propels the plot.

Female Identity, Widowhood and Property

Social Control over the Widow's Body

At the beginning of the story, widowhood appears as a social destiny. It means not only the loss of a husband but also restrictions upon dress, behaviour, travel, laughter, affection and the desire for a future. Shashitara questions these restrictions less through direct speeches than through the continued assertion of her personality. Society's doubt that an older woman might be capable of love is a subtler manifestation of the same prejudice.

The Politics of Service

The household readily asserts a claim over the labour and time of the person it respectfully calls 'Pisi'. A critical reading of the story reveals that even the language of gratitude can at times become an instrument of social control. Service freely given has value; when it is made a woman's only recognised social role, other aspects of her humanity are denied.

Land Inherited through the Marital Family and the Right to Decide

The question of land reveals the actual balance of power within the household. Attempts to restrict rights vested in a woman in the name of the family's collective interest take the form of questions and counterarguments. To dismiss Shashitara's position as greed or obstinacy would obscure the fundamental issue of economic autonomy. The physical structure of the house and the woman's psychological sense of 'home' give meaning to one another.

Love in Later Life: From Prohibition to Companionship

The intimacy gradually developing between Master Ramesh and Shashitara remains under the constant shadow of public shame. The story asks the reader to recognise the possibility of emotional companionship beyond bodily age, marital history and social convention. This does not amount to a simple rejection of conventional family life; it emphasises the ethical conditions of love—respect, reciprocity and free choice.

An Alternative Basis for Kinship

Towards the end of the story, the recurrence of the word ‘हमर’ (hamar, 'my' or 'mine') becomes significant. Belonging is established not solely through blood relationships but also through a willingness to share one another's joys and sorrows. This call to enlarge the definition of family is one of the narrative's human achievements.

Applying Translation Theory

A distinction must remain clear throughout any criticism of the Maithili translation: (a) what is actually observable in the translated Maithili text, and (b) how it differs from the Bengali original. The first question can be answered

from the available text; an authoritative answer to the second requires a line-by-line comparison with the Bengali original. The application of theory below is confined to the first question.

Nida's Formal and Dynamic Equivalence

Eugene Nida emphasised the closest natural equivalent of the original message in translation. Formal equivalence gives priority to proximity to the original form and linguistic structure, while dynamic equivalence seeks a comparable effect of meaning upon the reader. From the perspective of making the dialogue of Monak Pauti sound natural to a reader or listener of the target language, the presence of familiar Maithili forms such as 'अहाँ' (ahan), 'हमर' (hamar), 'किएक' (kiek), 'तँ' (ta) and 'छिऐ' (chhiai) suggests possible adaptations associated with dynamic equivalence. In the absence of the original Bengali lines, however, it would be unjustified to claim that any particular sentence has demonstrably been translated in a dynamic-equivalence mode.

Venuti: Domestication and Foreignisation

Lawrence Venuti's two strategies invite consideration together in this book. Kinship terms such as 'पीसी' (Pisi), 'भोजी' (Bhoji), 'माय' (Mai) and 'बाबूजी' (Babuji) create a familiarity accessible to readers of the target language—an effect of domestication. Conversely, surnames such as 'Chattopadhyay' and 'Bandyopadhyay', together with signs of Bengal's local social world, preserve evidence of a distinct cultural origin—an instance of retaining foreign cultural markers. Both strategies may coexist in a single work; they should not be evaluated through the binary of 'pure' versus 'impure'.

The Difference between Fidelity to Content and Fidelity to Feeling

The true problem of translation is not merely finding dictionary equivalents. A woman's silence, a suppressed smile, public sarcasm, the violence implicit in familial authority and the diffidence of love in old age all reside in how the story is told. In such contexts, a literal rendering can drain a character's voice of vitality. The natural presence of conversational rhythm and socially meaningful forms of address in the Maithili translation provides important textual evidence for analysing fidelity to feeling.

Testing Syntactic Transformation

Bengali and Maithili belong to closely related linguistic environments in eastern India, but their case-marking, verbs, honorific systems and sentence endings are not identical. In Maithili, for instance, relational markers such as 'क', 'सँ', 'मे' and 'लेल', and verb forms such as 'छथि', 'छलथि' and 'होइत अछि', signal social distance between characters. Translation criticism must examine sentence division, signs of direct speech, degrees of verbal honorification and the placement of particles. The available text's narrative paragraphs and frequent short exchanges appear consonant with the target

language's own character; identifying actual 'shifts' from the original would require a parallel Bengali text.

Skopos, or a Purpose-Oriented Perspective

Purpose-oriented theory asks: for whom, and for what cultural purpose, has this work been translated? In her preface (pp. 5–6), Kamla Chaudhary stresses the importance of bringing literary works from Bengali into Maithili. Making the novella's aesthetic qualities, emotional world and social questions accessible to ordinary Maithili readers is therefore a reasonable reader-oriented purpose. Living everyday Maithili, intelligible narration and meaningful expression serve that purpose. Reader accommodation must not, however, become a pretext for erasing the distinctive image of the Bengali setting.

The Translator's Visibility

The translator's name appears prominently on the cover, title page and in the preface. This gives grounds for treating translation not as inert transportation but as an act of creative choice. Colloquial expressions, terms of relationship, sentence rhythm and cultural mediation illuminate the creative labour of the target language. Criticism must recognise the translator's achievement in its own right, distinct from the original author's creative work.

Maithili Language, Dialogue and Cultural Vocabulary

Characteristics of Linguistic Form

The printed text prominently features Maithili pronouns, honorific verbs, interrogative particles, relational suffixes and familiar compound expressions. Forms such as ‘अहाँ’, ‘हम’, ‘हुनका’, ‘हमर’, ‘की’, ‘किएक’, ‘सँ’ and ‘तँ’ lend the language social specificity. At numerous points, the language of the narrator and that of the dialogue remain close, but shifts in a character's circumstances also change the tone of words. This is an important potential strength of the translation.

The Social Grammar of Forms of Address

'Pisi', 'Babuji', 'Bhoji', 'Master' and 'Mai' do not merely designate kinship relations: they establish relations of respect, age, authority and belonging. A change in the form of address used for a single character can alter the significance of an event. The translator's choice of address terms is as important as the plot itself in enabling the reader to recognise a character's social position.

Text-Based Linguistic Examples: An Annotated List

Word or expression	Source pages	Function in translation criticism
पीसी (Pisi)	8–21, 41	Age, family ties and social expectation

Word or expression	Source pages	Function in translation criticism
अजिया (Ajiya)	8	The intimate domestic meaning of an affectionate kinship term
फूल / फूलपुर (flower / Phulpur)	16–18, 78–89	Worship, memory, place and human attachment
भोजी (Bhoji)	28, 48–63	Intimacy and respect for age within relationships
मास्टर (Master)	20–21, 45–89	From occupational designation to personal relationship
हिस्सा (share)	33–34, 50–69	Conflict over property and autonomous decision-making
जमीन (land)	32–34, 64–77	A concrete emblem of economic rights
मकान (building/house)	33–39, 67, 74–79	From a place of residence to a metaphor of self-creation
हमर (my/mine)	66–69, 78–83	Questions of ownership and affection alike
रंग-रूप (appearance)	37–40, 48–49	Difference between outward beauty and human worth
मन्दिर (temple)	12–13, 44, 55	Tension between religiosity and public welfare
बुढ़ापा / वयस (old age /age)	60–64, 85–89	Social regulation of human desire

The Meaning of Linguistic Purity

Purity in Maithili does not mean eliminating every mark of historical contact with other languages. Genuine linguistic fidelity consists in preserving the Bengali cultural context of the original novella while keeping the working grammar, honorific distinctions, verbs, registers and idioms of Maithili alive. The reader consequently recognises the speech as belonging to everyday life, while the Bengali story retains its distinctive setting. The quality of literary translation should be judged against such a balance.

The Dramatic Quality of Dialogue

Dialogue in the translation is often brief, incisive and built around questions and answers. Characters' utterances contain half-spoken meanings, humour, barbs, uncertainty and the implications of silence. Comparing the dialogues about property shares on pages 50–55 with those concerning affection on pages 85–89 makes it clear that the same language can convey both the sharpness of accusation and the tenderness of intimacy. This narrative rhythm is a tangible achievement of the translator.

Narrative Technique, Time and Symbolism

The Sequence of Memory and the Movement of the Present

The narrative moves between memories of the past and work in the present. Shashitara's experience of her husband's death, the former organisation of the household and familial expectations create the weight of the past. Meanwhile, new land, a house, economic decisions and increasing closeness to Ramesh give momentum to the present. This temporal collision makes the reader understand that an older woman's life is not merely surviving history but a present still in formation.

The Symbolism of Flowers

Flowers carry multiple meanings associated with home, worship, affection and transient beauty. At the beginning, scenes involving flowers are connected to domestic labour and religious practice; towards the end, they can acquire a new emotional significance. It would be inappropriate to assign the flower one fixed meaning at every appearance: its meaning changes with context.

A Building versus a Home

'Makan' denotes a physical structure of brick and stone, whereas 'ghar' evokes the experience of being recognised as belonging. The question of rights over the old building is interwoven with the dream of new construction. Land and the house make visible a question: does a person whom the family calls 'one of our own' possess the right to decide?

The Function of Humour and Irony

Shashitara's laughter and the light teasing of those close to her often conceal serious meanings. Laughter does not erase suffering; it becomes a

means of bearing life's complexity. Because of this subtle cadence, the author's social criticism is not confined to strident declarations.

An Open Ending

The final scene should be understood in terms of ethical acceptance rather than presented as proof of a definitive decision to marry. Ramesh's words and Shashitara's change of mind suggest emerging forms of love and responsibility. The reader gains an awareness that transformation is possible even late in life.

The Translator's Achievements and Critical Questions

Achievements Visible in the Available Text

First, for the Maithili reader, the narrative becomes living domestic prose; dialogue performs a social act rather than simply conveying words. Second, tangible signs of the Bengali background survive in surnames and setting, avoiding the artificiality of a complete relocation. Third, in communicating the subtle feelings attached to women's rights and personal affection, the gentleness of language and the rigour of argument reinforce one another. Fourth, the translator attempts to explain her literary purpose in the preface.

Four Questions for Critical Examination

1. Do the honorific verb forms used by a given character remain consistent throughout the text, or do they change with circumstances?

2. Where a Maithili term replaces a Bengali cultural marker, has any of the original local significance been diminished?

3. In emotionally sensitive scenes, are the narrator's voice and the characters' voices clearly distinguishable?

4. Are the legal and social terms associated with land, property, family and inheritance used consistently?

The Bengali Title and Its Relationship to the Narrative

The publication details of Monak Pauti identify Moner Jhanpi as the original Bengali title. On the other hand, the sequence of events in the Shashitara narrative associated with the title Sonar Kouto ('The Golden Box'; Bengali: সোনার কৌটো) closely corresponds to this Maithili translation. The references to Phulpur, child widowhood, Ajit's legal advice, Birnagar, Rajbala, Master Ramesh, the sale of land to renovate the house and the metaphor of a new life all substantiate this affinity. The publication history underlying the difference in titles is a separate bibliographical question.

There are at least two possibilities: the source may have been a different Bengali edition, or the Maithili title may have been chosen as an emotionally resonant renaming. In the absence of direct publishing evidence, neither possibility should be treated as an established historical conclusion.

For comparison, the narrative progression of Sonar Kouto can be read in five units of episodes. Monak Pauti, however, runs continuously from pages 7

to 89 in Maithili. The five units are consequently an arrangement for comparative criticism, not a verified chapter division made by the original author.

Shashitara's rights as a widow must be understood through the contrast between property inherited through her marital family and memories of her natal home. To call the land merely 'paternal property' would diminish the significance of the narrative context. The final metaphor of love cannot, likewise, be reduced to personal attraction towards Master Ramesh.

Skopos-Oriented and Feminist Translation Criticism

For a Maithili readership, the translator's purpose is not simply to transmit Bengali information: it is also to bring Shashitara's agency, distress, humour, family relationships and constraints to life within Maithili experience. A feminist reading of the translation must avoid representing a widow's rights one-sidedly as charity, or making male approval the cause of her liberation.

Five Comparative Units of Narrative Content

Bengali narrative unit	Approximate Maithili printed pages	Principal narrative situation
1	7–21/22	Phulpur, childhood, widowhood, village arrangements, orphaned teacher
2	21/22–39	Community service, Ajit's advice, arrival at Birnagar, old house
3	39–54	Rajbala, Ramesh, memory, the history of the house, relations of "mine"
4	55–73	Temple, family tensions, sale of land, renovation, Jivesh's objection
5 (Shashitara story only)	73–89	Ajit's reaction, a new residence, Phulpur's response, final metaphor of love

A Detailed Comparison of Seventy-Five Narrative Instances

The following seventy-five narrative instances provide a sequential comparative discussion of the Bengali narrative content and the Maithili translation. Each point records the Bengali episode, the page of the Maithili book and a critical interpretation. Together they cover the events of the entire work, but they do not constitute a definitive bilingual edition of word-for-word textual variants.

Comparative Section 1: Village Life, Child Widowhood and Social Power

Bengali evidence: Sonar Kouto, Part 1; Maithili correspondences: printed pages cited below.

01 | Maithili p. 7 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Whispers of extraordinary news in Phulpur

Maithili textual indication: A curiosity-arousing opening with “खबरि अछि जोरदार” (“There is sensational news”)

Critical comment: Fidelity to the narrative premise combined with the natural surprise of spoken language; a comparable opening rhythm.

02 | Maithili p. 7–8 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Astonishment at a journey to the marital home, neglected for many years

Maithili textual indication: A succession of questions concerning Shashitara’s visit to her marital family

Critical comment: The sequence of brief questions turns astonishment into a collective psychological response.

03 | Maithili p. 8 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: A body altered in appearance, hair and condition by severe fasting

Maithili textual indication: A contrast between former beauty and present austerity

Critical comment: The crucial criterion is the preservation of the sharp irony in the figurative description of appearance.

04 | Maithili p. 8–9 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Marriage and widowhood at the age of nine

Maithili textual indication: Child marriage and the social construction of widowhood

Critical comment: The violence of a social order, not merely an individual's misfortune.

05 | Maithili p. 9–10 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Aghor Chattopadhyay's control over the lineage

Maithili textual indication: The grandfather's authority and his opposition to remarriage

Critical comment: The vocabulary of lineage and religion denotes political power.

06 | Maithili p. 9–10 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Shashitara's father's wish for her remarriage

Maithili textual indication: The conflict between father and grandfather

Critical comment: The failure of a possible alternative future for a woman's life.

07 | Maithili p. 10–11 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Climbing bamboo, gathering mangoes and becoming a child widow

Maithili textual indication: The spirited child's temperament and memories in old age

Critical comment: The double effect of irony and pathos must be kept equivalent.

08 | Maithili p. 11–12 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Shashitara's practical command over every household in the village

Maithili textual indication: A guardian of the village who also manages domestic affairs

Critical comment: The protagonist is not only a victim but also a central force in the narrative structure.

09 | Maithili p. 12–13 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Nanibala's sick granddaughter and financial assistance

Maithili textual indication: The episode of giving money to a family facing illness

Critical comment: Compassion beneath harsh words; fidelity to feeling is more important here than literal correspondence.

10 | Maithili p. 13–14 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Assistance with marriage arrangements in Satyacharan's family

Maithili textual indication: A gift given in recognition of a daughter's needs

Critical comment: Not charity, but an ethic of social interdependence.

11 | Maithili p. 14–15 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: An oil charm and the family's faith in it

Maithili textual indication: Shobha's mother and a folk belief in the medicinal uses of oil

Critical comment: The distinction between humour about folk belief and ridicule of it.

12 | Maithili p. 15–16 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Directions concerning family meals, weather, worship and household stores

Maithili textual indication: Shashitara's instructions for running the household

Critical comment: Sentences built as lists create the rhythmic impression of her energy.

13 | Maithili p. 16–17 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: No opportunity to look at the groom at the wedding

Maithili textual indication: The nine-year-old girl's obstinacy and her failure to see the groom

Critical comment: A point at which the narrator's tender irony can be tested.

14 | Maithili p. 17–18 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The concern of the inhabitants of Phulpur at her departure

Maithili textual indication: The village's communal dependence upon her

Critical comment: The underlying textual meaning is that the village functions through one woman's labour.

15 | Maithili p. 18–20 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Bathing at daybreak, gathering flowers and scolding children

Maithili textual indication: Daily routines and a commanding voice

Critical comment: The dual character of household responsibility and public moral surveillance.

16 | Maithili p. 20–21 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Everyday conversations with the orphaned schoolteacher

Maithili textual indication: A schoolteacher and the form of address “Pisi”

Critical comment: The system of vernacular forms of address should be understood, not merely Sanskritised.

Comparative Section 2: Service to the Village, Legal Claims and Birnagar

Bengali evidence: Sonar Kouto, Part 2; Maithili correspondences: printed pages cited below.

17 | Maithili p. 21–22 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The orphaned man's age and an old relationship

Maithili textual indication: Shashitara being addressed as “Pisi”

Critical comment: The social relationship signified by “Pisi” outside the biological family must not disappear.

18 | Maithili p. 22–23 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Work and study in Naru Basu's household

Maithili textual indication: Assistance to an unemployed person's family

Critical comment: The ethics of direct and indirect acts of help is a central concern.

19 | Maithili p. 23–24 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The delicate domestic labour of Naru's wife

Maithili textual indication: Economic support generated by preparing food, badi and pickles

Critical comment: The translation must retain respect for labour and an awareness of class distinctions.

20 | Maithili p. 24–25 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The prohibition on labour for a respectable woman, as opposed to a woman of the “lower orders”

Maithili textual indication: Attitudes to women's labour differentiated by caste and class

Critical comment: Shashitara's statement must not be treated as the author's final position.

21 | Maithili p. 25–26 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Bipin the physician, his mother, a tooth-cleaning twig and remedies

Maithili textual indication: Folk medicine and care for a mother

Critical comment: Preserve both the sarcasm and the culture of traditional healing.

22 | Maithili p. 26–27 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Food assistance for a poor family

Maithili textual indication: An indirect means of distributing food

Critical comment: Subtle practical assistance, rather than abstract philosophical humanism.

23 | Maithili p. 27–29 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Religious language and claims about public welfare

Maithili textual indication: An ironic cadence amid moral exhortation

Critical comment: The double edge of the irony contributes to the character's complexity.

24 | Maithili p. 29–30 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Timetables, women's bodies and food

Maithili textual indication: Shashitara's discipline

Critical comment: When the rhythm of repetition is cut, the voice loses some of its force.

25 | Maithili p. 30–32 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: News of property in Shashitara's marital family reaching Ajit

Maithili textual indication: The awakening of hope concerning a claim to property

Critical comment: Shashitara's claim concerns inheritance through her marital family; it raises questions of a woman's legal ownership and justice within the family.

26 | Maithili p. 32–34 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The death of an elder mother-in-law and the claims of inheritance

Maithili textual indication: A conversation about inheritance after the old mother-in-law's death

Critical comment: The timing of death and the basis of legal entitlement are distinct causal elements.

27 | Maithili p. 34–35 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: A share of land and its legal reckoning

Maithili textual indication: Bighas, sums of money and a lawyer's explanation

Critical comment: Keep the numerical sequence clear; do not present conjecture about the law as established fact.

28 | Maithili p. 35–36 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The journey to Birnagar with Ajit

Maithili textual indication: Preparation not merely for a visit but for residence

Critical comment: The act of travelling is a dramatic gesture of social rebellion.

29 | Maithili p. 36–37 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Observance of Ekadashi and bringing necessary supplies

Maithili textual indication: A widow arriving at the house without having eaten or drunk

Critical comment: Fasting is both a discipline imposed upon women and a strategic convenience.

30 | Maithili p. 37–38 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The first meeting with Rajbala and the offering of respect

Maithili textual indication: The arrival of an unfamiliar senior daughter-in-law in the family

Critical comment: Conflict over the social authority of the "Barki Bou" (senior daughter-in-law).

31 | Maithili p. 38 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The guest arranging her own meals

Maithili textual indication: Independence and Rajbala's discomfort

Critical comment: Narrative conflict emerges through the language of hospitality.

32 | Maithili p. 38–39 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Childhood memories awakened by the sight of a dilapidated building

Maithili textual indication: The familiarity of the house's walls and staircase

Critical comment: Memory and ownership are different layers of experience.

Comparative Section 3: Home, Memory and Family Conflict

Bengali evidence: Sonar Kouto, Part 3; Maithili correspondences: printed pages cited below.

33 | Maithili p. 39 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: An extremely old house within a modern town

Maithili textual indication: Birnagar's modernity and the building's inertia

Critical comment: A metaphor of past and present: the old house is a repository of earlier life.

34 | Maithili p. 39–40 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Calling property belonging to the marital family "mine"

Maithili textual indication: The expression "हमर ससुर" ("my father-in-law")

Critical comment: A form of address itself becomes a legal and emotional claim.

35 | Maithili p. 40–41 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Rajbala's fear that her family's share will diminish

Maithili textual indication: The household's restricted conception of ownership

Critical comment: Identify the social roots of antagonism towards another woman, rather than merely making Rajbala a villain.

36 | Maithili p. 41–43 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The younger brother-in-law's family and the temple's presence

Maithili textual indication: Old memories associated with the goddess's temple

Critical comment: The conjunction of sacred space and marital memory.

37 | Maithili p. 43–44 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The bathing steps of the pond and domestic neglect

Maithili textual indication: Recognition of shortcomings in the building's structure

Critical comment: Architectural description becomes the construction of an emotional foundation.

38 | Maithili p. 44–46 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ramesh's appearance and the form of address "Bhoujai" (sister-in-law)

Maithili textual indication: The meeting between Master Ramesh and Shashitara

Critical comment: Relations are kept alive by memory, even more than by blood.

39 | Maithili p. 46–47 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The moment of marriage recalled by Ramesh as a boy

Maithili textual indication: Recollection of Shashitara's appearance as a young bride

Critical comment: The mirror of memory holds different ages together.

40 | Maithili p. 47–48 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Seeing the new bride as a fairy or princess

Maithili textual indication: "Pari-Bou" ("fairy bride") and Shashitara's laughter

Critical comment: If the power of recollection is diminished, the narrative consciousness is affected.

41 | Maithili p. 48–49 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Alpana designs in the courtyard, adornment and jewellery

Maithili textual indication: Recovery of Shashitara's forgotten image

Critical comment: Memory answers the social suppression of the body.

42 | Maithili p. 49 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Speaking of "my" home after a very long interval

Maithili textual indication: An experience of familial belonging

Critical comment: Emotional union and a claim to property are not synonymous.

43 | Maithili p. 50–51 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Rajbala voicing her doubts to her daughter Anna

Maithili textual indication: Antagonism towards Shashitara

Critical comment: Read Rajbala's fear in relation to economic security.

44 | Maithili p. 51–52 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Sweets for the grandchildren and accusations of enchantment

Maithili textual indication: Ramesh bringing sweets

Critical comment: The same object becomes "affection" to one person and "favouritism" to another.

45 | Maithili p. 52–53 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The unease of Anna, a widow, in the house

Maithili textual indication: The daughter's card-playing and excursions outside the home

Critical comment: Retain the character's harsh voice without omitting the context of her speech.

46 | Maithili p. 53–54 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ramesh's experience of finding support within himself

Maithili textual indication: Renewed confidence arising from Shashitara's presence

Critical comment: The male character too has been dependent: a reversal of the centre of power.

Comparative Section 4: Cooperation and the Reconstruction of Home

Bengali evidence: Sonar Kouto, Part 4; Maithili correspondences: printed pages cited below.

47 | Maithili p. 55 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ramesh failing to receive the trust he expects from his family

Maithili textual indication: His reserve in the presence of Rajbala and the children

Critical comment: Male vulnerability and Shashitara's protective role.

48 | Maithili p. 55–56 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Temple arati, sweets and courtesy

Maithili textual indication: Ramesh accompanying Shashitara to the temple

Critical comment: The conventions of respect become a focus of conflict.

49 | Maithili p. 56–57 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The form of address for the newly arrived senior sister-in-law

Maithili textual indication: The standing conferred by Ramesh's "Barki Bhoji"

Critical comment: The equivalence of intimacy expressed through Maithili kinship address.

50 | Maithili p. 57–58 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Anna's widowhood and the episode of playing cards

Maithili textual indication: Shashitara reproving the daughter over her conduct

Critical comment: A feminist reading must also identify patriarchal morality.

51 | Maithili p. 58–59 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ramesh's growing self-confidence

Maithili textual indication: More voices and conversation in the courtyard

Critical comment: A movement from domestic communicative deprivation towards dialogue.

52 | Maithili p. 59–60 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Rajbala's suspicion and sarcasm

Maithili textual indication: New alignments within the household

Critical comment: No character's words should automatically be taken as the author's endorsement.

53 | Maithili p. 60–61 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: A concrete proposal to repair the house

Maithili textual indication: Remedies for the dilapidated state of domestic arrangements

Critical comment: Rebuilding the house gives emotional rebirth a material form.

54 | Maithili p. 61–63 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ramesh wanting to transform the house with new enthusiasm

Maithili textual indication: The diminishing of his inner fear

Critical comment: The recovery of male agency through Shashitara's support.

55 | Maithili p. 63–64 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: A prospective buyer for the land and conditions concerning shares

Maithili textual indication: The decision to spend money from one's own share

Critical comment: An economic arrangement: rights must not be turned into charity.

56 | Maithili p. 64–66 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: An account involving ten bighas and ten thousand rupees

Maithili textual indication: Money from the property directed towards rebuilding the marital family's house

Critical comment: Both passages should be reread to verify the numbers.

57 | Maithili p. 66–68 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ramesh's hesitation and the invitation to stay in the house

Maithili textual indication: Mutual assurances of shelter

Critical comment: The relationship of "we" is still being constructed; this is not superficial romance.

58 | Maithili p. 68–70 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Suspicions among outsiders

Maithili textual indication: Accusations about a woman's influence

Critical comment: Public condemnation is not the novel's moral centre.

59 | Maithili p. 70–72 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Jivesh objecting to the sale of land

Maithili textual indication: The son's questions and the father's silence

Critical comment: Intergenerational conflict over labour, rights and authority.

60 | Maithili p. 72–73 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Shashitara openly defending her rights

Maithili textual indication: A declaration of her own decision during a dispute

Critical comment: The distinction between legal entitlement and condescending charity is crucial.

Comparative Section 5: New Life, Belonging and the Final Metaphor

Bengali evidence: Sonar Kouto, Part 5; Maithili correspondences: printed pages cited below.

61 | Maithili p. 73–74 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ajit's objection: why not profit from selling the land?

Maithili textual indication: A conversation with her nephew, the lawyer

Critical comment: Choosing responsibility for the house over financial gain.

62 | Maithili p. 74–75 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The old house likened to a diseased body

Maithili textual indication: The medical metaphor of renovation as treatment

Critical comment: The image of healing intensifies the emotional force of the original metaphor.

63 | Maithili p. 75–77 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: A well, pump and new plans for the house

Maithili textual indication: Discussion of a tubewell and construction

Critical comment: Progress is not merely urban development: it also lies in the shared labour of the household.

64 | Maithili p. 77–79 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The prospect of electricity and reflections on light

Maithili textual indication: Plans to introduce new illumination into the house

Critical comment: Physical electricity and mental illumination function as parallel symbols.

65 | Maithili p. 79–80 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The pleasure of saying “amar” (“mine”) awakening in a new form

Maithili textual indication: An experience of belonging that exceeds formal property rights

Critical comment: The movement from ruler or servant towards a participant.

66 | Maithili p. 80–82 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Responses in Phulpur to Shashitara's absence

Maithili textual indication: Her absence being felt in the old household

Critical comment: The village's dependence on her may also be mixed with self-interest.

67 | Maithili p. 82–83 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Pari's wedding and a brief return to the old home

Maithili textual indication: Spending only a short time at the invitation

Critical comment: The usefulness-based character of ties to the former village comes under scrutiny.

68 | Maithili p. 83–84 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The fading appeal of former forms of control

Maithili textual indication: Surprise at herself as a result of new experiences

Critical comment: An active transformation, not a sudden abandonment of religion.

69 | Maithili p. 84–85 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Ramesh coming to the wedding invitation

Maithili textual indication: A new companionship viewed through the eyes of the old world

Critical comment: Social gossip becomes an instrument of poetic irony.

70 | Maithili p. 85–86 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Returning together to Birnagar

Maithili textual indication: The joy of the journey

Critical comment: The train journey signifies displacement at first and liberation at the end.

71 | Maithili p. 86–87 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Public slander and a woman's decision

Maithili textual indication: Shashitara's unawareness of, or resistance to, defamatory talk

Critical comment: Social surveillance of an independent widow's movements.

72 | Maithili p. 87–88 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Discussion of new household work while travelling with Ramesh

Maithili textual indication: A letter about electricity and the work of labourers

Critical comment: The home's new life is demonstrated through everyday activity.

73 | Maithili p. 88–89 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: Talk of living with Ramesh turning into a metaphor of love

Maithili textual indication: The experience of a previously unknown flavour of life

Critical comment: The underlying meaning is love of life; this alone does not prove an explicit declaration of sexual love.

74 | Maithili p. 89 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The metaphor of suppressed longings kept within a small casket

Maithili textual indication: The resonance of “Monak Pauti” at the conclusion of the Maithili text

Critical comment: The titles share a central imaginative concern, though the Bengali text also invokes gold and its value.

75 | Maithili p. 89 | Evidence A

Bengali episode: The conclusion of the Maithili narrative

Maithili textual indication: Shashitara's narrative arc ends with the final metaphor of love

Close Reading of Language, Dialogue and Cultural Meaning

Short Bengali–Maithili Evidence: Specific Textual Instances

The following examples place brief portions of Bengali expression beside the semantic relationships of their Maithili renderings. In deciding questions of textual variation, narrative content, tone, possible differences between editions and the translator's linguistic choices must be considered separately.

Bengali part	Maithili page	Bengali quotation or clue	Maithili form and interpretation
1	7–8	"খবরটা জবর বটে" ("That really is quite a piece of news")	"खबरि अछि जोरदार" ("There is sensational news"); amazement in dialogue; functional equivalence of the colloquial idiom.
1	10	"শশীতারা ফুলপুরের হৃদযন্ত্র" ("Shashitara is Phulpur's heart")	Shashitara understood as Phulpur's centre or vital force; the metaphor of social centrality survives despite a change of local idiom.
1	21	"পিসিমার পুণ্যের শরীর" ("Pisi's blessed person")	"पुण्यात्मा छी अहाँ, पीसी" ("You are a blessed soul, Pisi"); the communal grammar of respect and the religious register.
2	30–35	"ভাগ" ("share")	Discussion of entitlement to a share; the legal meaning attached to land; no warrant for adding the qualification "paternal".
2	39	"মনের জগতে" ("in the world of the mind")	Memories awakening within Shashitara; a metaphorical movement from mental space to the historical home.
3	39	"আমাদের শ্বশুর ঠাকুরের" ("of our revered father-in-law")	The means of saying "हमर ससुर" ("my father-in-law"); a strategic use of the possessive first person in a claim of belonging.
3	47–49	"পরীবৌ" ("fairy bride")	Memory of a young bride like a fairy; emotion and visuality; recovery of the body of the past.
4	66–68	"আমার শ্বশুরের ভিটে" ("my father-in-law's homestead")	A plan to build at the marital family's house; the narrative centre is the marital plot, not the natal village.
4	61–63	"একটা	A metaphor for Shashitara's importance within the household; an ironic comparison

Bengali part	Maithili page	Bengali quotation or clue	Maithili form and interpretation
		সম্পত্তি" ("a property / an asset")	of person and land/property.
১	79–80	"আমার" ("mine")	Experiencing the pleasure of having a home of one's own; the language of ownership opens her independent emotional world.
১	88–89	"সোনার কৌটায়" ("in the golden box")	The final comparison with Monak Pauti; a substantial re-creation of the title, moving from a Bengali golden or precious container to a treasure of the mind.

Forms of Address, Relationships and the Social Meaning of Translation

The Bengali terms 'পিসিমা' (pishima, paternal aunt), 'বড়বৌ' (borobou, senior daughter-in-law), 'ঠাকুরপো' (thakurpo, younger brother-in-law) and 'দ্যাওর' (deor, younger brother-in-law) are not simply kinship designations to be found in a dictionary. They encode the relationship between speaker and addressee, social distance, age and authority in the household. Near equivalents in Maithili, such as 'पीसी', 'बड़की भौजी' and 'ठाकुरपो/देवर', make the text more readily accessible to its readers. Yet the politics of social designation are present both when Ramesh addresses Shashitara as 'Barki Bhoji' and when Rajbala resents Shashitara's arrival. To generalise all of this as the pan-Indian 'bhabhi' could obscure the precise hierarchy of relations.

In the final episode of scandal, the translation of address terms and community designations is also connected with a social question: why do people seek to control a 'widow's' public interactions? The coexistence of 'Bhoji/Devar' kinship terminology with the implications of love creates a complex ethical space. To read the work as an uncomplicated romance would diminish the irony of the original.

Sentence Rhythm and the Narrator's Humour

At the beginning of the story, the excitement of spreading news is created through short sentences, successions of questions and colloquial exaggeration. Maithili expressions such as 'खबरि अछि जोरदार' ('There is sensational news'), 'की?' ('What?'), 'कखन?' ('When?') and 'सासुर?' ('The marital home?') reproduce the same social rhythm through fragmentary questions. This is a strength of the translation at the level of equivalence of effect. Turning such exchanges into long, compound-heavy sentences in the name of formal prose would destroy their awkward, comic tension.

The humour in the recurring lists of everyday instructions does not arise merely from the fact that Shashitara talks a great deal. It arises from the way she governs the family, courtyard, verandah, kitchen, flower-thieves and villagers in a single administrative rhythm. The recurrence of such injunctions in translation is not merely 'repetition'; it is a means of characterisation.

A Short Glossary of Cultural Terms: Meaning, Function and Problems of Translation

Bengali term or clue	Possible Maithili form	Social or metaphorical function
শ্বশুরবাড়ি (marital home)	सासुर / सासुरक घर	Relation established by marriage; old and new ownership
বৈধব্য (widowhood)	वैधव्य / विधवापन	Age and social punishment
পিসিমা (paternal aunt)	पीसी	Kinship address, age and authority
ঠাকুরপো (younger brother-in-law)	देवर /ठाकुरपो	Address for Ramesh; intimacy
বড়বৌ (senior daughter-in-law)	बड़की भौजी	The senior daughter-in-law of the household
দ্যাওর (younger brother-in-law)	देवर	The moral boundaries of kinship
একাদশী (Ekadashi)	एकादशी	Fasting and the female body
সিংহবাহিনী (lion-riding goddess)	सिंहवाहिनी	Local worship of the goddess
আলপনা (ritual floor design)	अरिपन /अल्पना	Marriage and remembered visual scenes
টিপকল (handpump)	चापाकल / टच्यूबवेल	Evidence of modernisation

Bengali term or clue	Possible Maithili form	Social or metaphorical function
ভিটে (homestead)	घर-डीह /भिट्टा	Land belonging to a natal or marital home
বিঘা (bigha)	बिघा	Measurement of land and comparability of units
জমি ভাগ (share of land)	जमिनक हिस्सा	The widow's economic rights
সতীন (co-wife)	सौत	Relations in a polygamous family
পৌত্রী (granddaughter)	पोती	Lineage and descent
তীর্থ (pilgrimage)	तीर्थ	Faith and travel
প্রণাম (salutation)	प्रणाम	Hierarchy and etiquette
মোহ (attachment)	मोह /आसक्ति	The individual as against love of life
কৌটো (small box)	डिबिया /पौती	Desires preserved within
সোনা (gold)	सोना /सुनहर	A symbol of what is precious
আমার (my/mine)	हमर /अपन	Rights and emotional ownership
আঙিনা (courtyard)	आँगन	Home, memory and society
মন্দির (temple)	मन्दिर	A marker of memory
পুনর্নির্মাণ (rebuilding)	जीर्णोद्धार	A metaphor of renewed life

The heading 'Possible Maithili form' in the following glossary does not imply that the translator actually used every form listed. Where a form is not directly quoted from the

printed pages, it functions as a tool for examining lexical relationships. In particular, the choice and possible obscuring of distinctions between 'aripan/alpana', 'chapakal/tubewell' and 'dibiya/pauti' require separate consideration.

The Change of Title, Ownership and the Reconstruction of Home

From Sonar Kouto to Monak Pauti: A Theory of Titular Transformation

The ordinary meaning of the Bengali title Sonar Kouto ('The Golden Box') is a little golden box or a small, precious receptacle. By the conclusion, the narrative can be read as imagining Shashitara's happiness in life as something nurtured and concealed within a precious, private container. The Maithili title Monak Pauti moves the emphasis from material gold to the hidden desires of the mind. It may therefore be regarded as a possible purpose-oriented transformation of the title. Yet because the publication details mention Moner Jhanpi, it is appropriate to leave the history of the original Bengali title unresolved.

The central caution is twofold: it would be mistaken to assume that Sonar Kouto and Monak Pauti are different narratives merely because their titles differ; it would be equally mistaken to regard their publication histories as beyond dispute merely because their stories coincide. Textual comparison and bibliographical verification are two distinct research tasks.

The Natal Village versus the Marital Home: A New Geography of Ownership

Shashitara has spent most of her life in Phulpur, the village of her parents. Her labour there, customary practices, the people and the family's dependence upon her have therefore given her public authority. At Birnagar she encounters the dilapidated house of her husband's family, memories of her former marriage and the possibility of inheritance. In both the Bengali and Maithili narratives, the episode concerning land is fundamentally a question of reviving the marital family's home. This is not a trivial correction of terminology: it changes the entire direction of interpretation towards a woman's right to choose her own home.

The Effacement of Bodily Beauty and the Return of Beauty through Memory

A girl of nine, a complexion likened to unrefined gold, the sacrifice of hair on pilgrimage, a body altered by fasting and an unflinching face in old age—together these episodes inscribe social history upon Shashitara's body. In Ramesh's recollection the young bride comes alive again like a fairy. This scene reveals the personhood suppressed under Shashitara's lifelong widowhood. The contrast between an austere present and an almost otherworldly memory needs to remain present in translation.

Building a Home: Money, Masons, Courtyard, Handpump and Electricity

The land dispute at the centre of the story ultimately becomes an attempt to transform the very ground of the house. The plans for a tubewell, improvements to the well, levelling the courtyard, painting, doors, walls and electricity are indispensable narrative events. If treated merely as background, Shashitara's love of life would become an unstable symbol without material

grounding. Ramesh's release from fear and his recovered self-respect are also connected with this process.

The Many Meanings of Love at the Ending

The final Bengali suggestion links love with the experience of discovering a previously unknown taste for life. In the Maithili ending, too, desires long suppressed within Shashitara begin to stir. Shared plans with Master Ramesh, conversations grounded in mutual respect and travelling together are practical expressions of this feeling. The public gaze sees disgrace in them; the narrator reverses the language of disgrace into an acceptance of renewed consciousness. It would therefore be equally one-sided to summarise the ending as 'marriage-like romantic love for Ramesh' or as 'nothing but love for a building'.

Rajbala and Anna: Women's Suffering on the Opposing Side

Rajbala has spent her life under the authority of her mother-in-law and hopes to control her household freely in old age. Shashitara's arrival rekindles her fear of earlier subordination and of the division of land. Anna is herself a widow; her card-playing, excursions outside the house and struggle against others' discipline also reveal patriarchal conventions. Although Shashitara appears as a figure of liberation, her stern instructions can themselves at times oppose women's autonomy. This internal contradiction must not be eliminated from the translated narrative's voice.

The Translator's Achievement and Critical Evaluation

Achievements Supported by the Available Text

• The vigorous rhythm of an opening built around news and the collective voice of the community remain alive in Maithili.

• Local Maithili forms of address make Shashitara not a figure of formal history but a living member of the community's domestic world.

• The emotional continuity of memory remains intact from child widowhood to old age, and the story's chronology is intelligible.

• The multilayered conflict of rights among Ajit, Rajbala, Ramesh, Anna and Jivesh appears to have been preserved.

• Concrete episodes involving repairs to the house, land transactions, the temple and train travel give the final image a social foundation.

• The concluding metaphor of Monak Pauti clarifies the psychological centre of the work; it is a persuasive possibility for a creative alternative title.

Conditions of Criticism: Where an 'Omission' Cannot Be Asserted

Some expressions appear stylistically different in the Bengali and Maithili texts. In view of the possibility of variant textual editions, however, semantic difference by itself does not establish the accusation that the translator has 'cut a sentence from the original'. The present discussion therefore evaluates correspondences of narrative content, register and symbolism; it does not fabricate a list of omissions unsupported by evidence.

Monak Pauti: Overall Conclusion

Monak Pauti is not simply a story about the benevolent travels of an elderly widow. It is a complex narrative of deprivation within marriage, social control, the invisible value of domestic labour, a widow's property rights and the possibility of a new life. From beginning to end it has substantial affinities with the narrative content of the Bengali Sonar Kouto. The colloquial quality of the Maithili dialogue, its familial forms of address and its imaginative reworking of metaphor preserve the social intensity of the work.

The most important subsequent transformation lies in the fact that land and money initially form the basis of the claim to rights, but the land's value ultimately becomes the reconstruction of a home and the affirmation of individual personhood. Without attention to Ajit's legal reasoning, Rajbala's insecurity, Ramesh's emergence from helplessness and Shashitara's newly discovered world of belonging, the final metaphor of love remains incomplete. A woman's self-determination is the novella's backbone.

The comparison of seventy-five narrative instances makes possible an extensive assessment of narrative movement, character relations and thematic equivalence. Any claim of word-for-word identity or of specific omissions would require a more detailed comparison of the complete texts of the printed editions of both works.

Chapter 2: Samay-Sanket — A Comprehensive Reading of All Fourteen Stories

Primary work: Kamla Chaudhary, Samay-Sanket, a collection of short stories, 2010. Original story pages: 13–104.

The Sequence of Stories and the Plan of Analysis

The original sequence of stories in Samay-Sanket has been retained. The page numbers given are those of the printed story collection.

No.	Story title	Original pages
1	Samay-Sanket (Signs of the Times)	13–18
2	Paigh Lok (Important People)	19–26
3	Badla (Revenge)	27–33
4	Dhuri (The Axle)	34–38
5	Gulab Kaki (Aunt Gulab)	39–48
6	Yuddh (War)	49–53
7	Gunanphal (The Product)	54–63

No.	Story title	Original pages
8	Akanksha (Aspiration)	64–71
9	Ahibatak Haar (Necklace of Marital Auspiciousness)	72–77
10	Kaal-Chakra (The Cycle of Time)	78–81
11	Drishtikon (Point of View)	82–88
12	Nirnay (Decision)	89–94
13	Baate Bilayal Pani (Water Lost Along the Way)	95–99
14	Aparajita (The Unvanquished)	100–104

The analysis focuses on the story titles, their order, characters, sequences of events and page references in Samay-Sanket. It also takes account of the intellectual contexts furnished by the introductory pieces entitled 'Lekhakiy' ('Author's Note') and 'Nari-Vimarshak Nari-Lekhani' ('A Woman's Pen Engaging with Women's Questions'). The content of each story is distinguished from its critical significance.

The Author's Narrative Outlook and the Collection's Governing Tone

The introductory essay 'Nari-Vimarshak Nari-Lekhani' and the author's own 'Lekhakiy', which appear at the beginning of the collection, open different pathways for the reader. The introduction emphasises the collection's woman-centred dimension. In discussing the social foundations of her fiction and female characters drawn from experience, the author attaches importance to family, circumstance and the contradictions of life. From a critical standpoint, the introduction, the author's self-statement and the stories themselves are not identical objects; each must be read separately.

The society represented in the collection is not divided simply into two antagonistic camps of women and men. The stories encompass rich and poor, young and old, the dependent and the self-reliant, those with and without physical disabilities, believers in tradition and people making new decisions. Women's struggles form an important connecting thread through this diversity.

Considered in sequence, the collection begins with Samay-Sanket, which depicts the awakening of an awareness of social rights, and ends with Aparajita, which emphasises the inner strength of an individual. The intervening stories ask how human dignity might be preserved at different

stages of life. This may be regarded as a possible overarching tone of the collection: it is a critical reading, not a verified statement of editorial intention.

Individual Critical Studies of the Fourteen Stories

Samay-Sanket (Signs of the Times)

Original pages: 13–18 | Principal characters or groups: Sukhna, Bilti, Raja Babu and Master Saheb

Narrative and setting: The story rests upon the social organisation of the village. Sukhna and Bilti live under the pressures of economic deprivation, labour and the denial of rights. Raja Babu's dominance represents an order in which ordinary people are apprehensive even about discussing their entitlements. Sukhna's state of mind at the outset makes this dependence and insecurity clear.

Development of conflict: The presence of Master Saheb introduces a new direction of thought. Discussion of rights, the village's public arrangements and participation in them confronts Sukhna with questions that concern not simply personal benefit but collective dignity. Sukhna stands between an old fear and a new consciousness. Bilti's practical experience also connects this change with the internal life of the household.

Ending and meaning: The ending clarifies the possibility of change. Awakening to one's rights does not immediately transform the balance of power, but it changes Sukhna's thinking. In this sense, the title Samay-Sanket signals a changing time. New circumstances encourage the villagers to understand their rights.

Narrative craft and critical assessment: Rural speech, dialogue and brief episodes of ordinary conduct carry the narrative forward. A far-reaching question of social transformation is contained within a character's private experience. To read it merely as a personal quarrel between Raja Babu and Sukhna would diminish its importance; the central concerns are social rights and self-respect. The achievement of the story is that it renders a change of consciousness credible through the unfolding of events.

Paigh Lok (Important People)

Original pages: 19–26 | Principal characters or groups: Preeta, Neelu and Memsaheb

Narrative and circumstances: The story opens through Preeta's experience. The need to earn a living brings her into a world where a sharp distinction exists between the materially privileged and those dependent upon their labour. Her affection for her daughter Neelu and anxiety about the child's future connect this economic issue with the experience of motherhood. Memsaheb's household and conduct reveal another face of outward prosperity.

Characters and relationships: The distance between Memsaheb's status and her conduct creates the story's critical tension. The respect Preeta hopes for is not automatically secured in a wealthy environment. Neelu is Preeta's

emotional centre, and the question of her welfare figures prominently in every decision her mother makes.

The title's implications: The expression paigh lok generally signifies people of wealth, rank and social influence. The story reverses this conventional meaning and turns it into an ethical question: does greatness reside in a person's position or in the heart? Preeta's experience compels the reader to consider this distinction.

Critical observations: The story's social foundation lies in the dignity of labour and respect for the human person. Although the class divide is clear, the narrative does not simply condemn luxury; it proposes humane standards of conduct. Preeta's perspective on her own village changes. In this way, belonging and self-respect are valued above the external glitter of society.

Badla (Revenge)

Original pages: 27–33 | Principal characters or groups: Reeta Bhauri, Haricharan and Satish

Narrative and focal concern: This story is founded upon bitterness within human relationships and the subsequent ethical trial. The experiences of Reeta Bhauri, Haricharan and Satish connect marriage, illness, service and memories of earlier hurt. When circumstances change, the suffering and vulnerability of a person formerly regarded with resentment become visible in a new way.

From revenge to compassion: The title Badla creates an expectation of revenge, but the progression of events complicates that expectation. Harsh treatment need not always receive a harsh response. Human sensitivity emerges as an alternative ethical answer. The story centres upon the question of what our duty towards another person ought to be at a moment of weakness.

The position of the female character: Reeta Bhauri's conduct may be understood in terms of forbearance and inner strength. Nevertheless, it is insufficient to idealise her service without further questioning. The unilateral expectation that women should serve and sacrifice can perpetuate social inequality. The story accordingly displays the woman's moral stature while giving the critic an opportunity to reconsider the value attached to sacrifice.

Narrative craft and evaluation: Changes in life circumstances alter the meaning of relationships. External events and internal psychological transformation develop together. The paradoxical significance of the title makes the story effective. Rather than treating it as a simple homily on forgiveness, it is more appropriate to read it as a complex account of suffering, responsibility and ethical choice.

Dhuri (The Axle)

Original pages: 34–38 | Principal characters or groups: Sheela and her family environment

Narrative: Sheela's life follows the familiar rhythm of domestic existence and family support. An accident involving her husband confronts her with an arduous reality in which emotional and economic security are called into

question together. The consequences of the event involve not only grief but the need to discover a means of continuing to live.

The woman's circumstances: The work of the woman who sustains a household is central to the narrative, but a crisis makes apparent that the capacity to decide may remain limited in a dependent existence. Sheela does not retreat from her responsibilities; changing circumstances require her to recognise her own abilities.

Title and symbol: Dhuri denotes the axle, the centre around which a wheel turns. The name symbolises household activity, familial organisation and the often unseen labour that sustains it. Rather than placing the woman only at the periphery, the story brings her central role into view.

Critical assessment: The story's principal achievement is to transform crisis into a question of self-reliance. Yet it also raises a further question: why must women so often wait for calamity before their competence can be recognised? Dhuri is therefore not simply a story of suffering; it insists upon women's need for social and economic independence.

Gulab Kaki (Aunt Gulab)

Original pages: 39–48 | Principal characters or groups: Gulab Kaki and the female narrator

Narrative setting: The neglected life of an elderly woman forms the centre of Gulab Kaki. Her experiences include deprivation, loneliness and social distance. Through the female narrator, the reader gradually comes to know the aunt's circumstances. A person whom ordinary society readily overlooks becomes the central subject of the story.

The creation of intimacy: Here a person's identity is established not by economic status or position in society but by lived experience. The narrator's conduct towards Kaki creates a humane space for sympathy. Small details of life bring into relief the insecurity of old age and the need to belong.

A distinctive concern of feminist criticism: The story addresses not only the rights of younger women but also the dignity of older women. When home, family or society begins to regard the elderly as no longer useful, their experience and emotional needs are obscured. Gulab Kaki's presence calls this inhuman attitude into question.

Language and craft: Memory, affectionate forms of address and details of everyday behaviour lend the narrative its pathos. In the title, the kinship term 'Kaki' attached to a personal name conveys a sense of familiarity. Through this story the author places a forgotten figure of ordinary life at the centre of literature.

Yuddh (War)

Original pages: 49–53 | Principal characters or groups: Rajesh, Chunnu and members of the family

Narrative: The dialogues and behaviour of Rajesh and Chunnu bring into view differences between generations, anxiety over livelihoods and familial expectations. One generation regards its own experience as authoritative,

while another seeks to make decisions in the light of changing circumstances. Thus, even ordinary domestic episodes become sites of ideological conflict.

The multiple meanings of 'war': The battle in the story is not fought upon a battlefield. It is a metaphor for the daily struggle among expectations, self-interest, responsibility, values and self-respect. Conflicts without weapons can leave deep marks upon the human mind.

Tensions between characters: Their differences reflect not just stubbornness but also the pressures of social change. Considering the younger generation's aspirations alongside the older generation's experience makes the story more meaningful. Declaring one side wholly right and the other wholly wrong would diminish its complexity.

Critical conclusion: The story's strength lies in conveying a wider consciousness of conflict through events of daily life. The distance between the title and the action encourages the reader to seek symbolic meaning. Family dialogue becomes a record of the transformation of social values.

Gunanphal (The Product)

Original pages: 54–63 | Principal characters or groups: Meera and Sunil

Narrative outline: In Meera and Sunil's married life, questions arise concerning the household, financial needs, the division of time and personal interests. Decisions that seem ordinary from the outside expose differences of power and expectation within marriage. A central concern of the story is how a woman's work and desires are valued.

Calculating human relationships: The title Gunanphal is a familiar mathematical word, 'product', but within the story it acquires emotional and social meanings. The reader is confronted by the question of what remains of individual freedom when human relationships are calculated in terms of convenience, utility, money and status.

The significance of Meera's character: Meera is not simply someone who fulfils the family's needs. She also has her own thoughts, wishes and understanding of life's meaning. Justice within marriage requires equal recognition of the labour and aspirations of both individuals. This proposition is an important critical foundation for reading the story.

Craft and conclusion: Through domestic events and the characters' reciprocal conduct, the story develops a social significance. An abstract question is brought down to the concrete accounts and calculations of everyday life. Gunanphal thereby exposes the tension between a utilitarian approach to marriage and the dignity of individual personhood.

Akanksha (Aspiration)

Original pages: 64–71 | Principal characters or groups: Chhavi and the family involved in raising her

The story's central situation: Through Chhavi's life, the narrative raises questions about upbringing, affection, protection and decisions concerning

one's own future. The family has its expectations; Chhavi has her aspirations. The two are not always in harmony.

The individual and the family: The story makes clear that, however important familial affection may be, it is not equivalent to complete authority over an individual's life. What the family considers right need not correspond to the young woman's actual wishes. Chhavi's experience reveals this complex difference.

A woman's self-determination: From the perspective of feminist criticism, Chhavi's personhood must remain at the centre. Her wishes, fears, hopes and understanding deserve due place in marriage and other decisions about her life. Aspiration is not merely a dream; it is a human insistence upon shaping one's own future.

Critical discussion: The story's emotional foundation does not weaken its social question; rather, it brings that question closer to the reader. The title signifies an unfulfilled wish within the individual. The story encourages a search for a just balance between familial protection and women's independence.

Ahibatak Haar (The Necklace of Marital Auspiciousness)

Original pages: 72–77 | Principal characters or groups: Ram Babu and his daughter Amola

Narrative circumstances: Social expectations surrounding marriage, dowry and concern for family honour are prominent in the story. From Ram Babu's point of view, the main problem is to secure his daughter's future in accordance with conventional arrangements. Amola's thinking, however, also includes the right to decide the course of her own life.

Symbolic meaning: Ahibatak Haar is a symbolic title associated with the traditional auspiciousness of married life. Through this title the author questions accepted assumptions about a woman's happiness and the fulfilment of her life. The completeness of a woman's personality cannot be determined by symbols of marriage alone.

Dowry and decision-making: The pressure of dowry turns marriage from a relationship between two persons into a matter of social transaction and prestige. Amola's point of view offers the possibility of independent thought in the face of this pressure. The father's concerns and the daughter's decisions need to be understood within the same social circumstances.

Critical assessment: Women's self-determination in this story is not simply an individual rebellion; it becomes a means of reconsidering social convention. The cultural meanings of the title give the narrative a distinctly Maithil social context. In this respect, it is an important text both for feminist criticism and for criticism of the dowry system.

Kaal-Chakra (The Cycle of Time)

Original pages: 78–81 | Principal characters or groups: Pran Kaki and Sudha

Time and relations between generations: Through Pran Kaki and Sudha, the story presents a difference in outlook between older and younger generations. Older beliefs concerning education, employment, marriage and women's futures encounter new demands arising from a changing society.

The movement of change: Time means more than the movement of a clock; it also names transformations in social thought, opportunity and conduct. The experience of one generation may be valuable to another, but cannot become an immutable rule applicable to every situation.

Feminist concerns: The story reveals the difference between older communal expectations of women's lives and newer claims to self-reliance. Education and employment open new possibilities for women. To understand the change, however, the context of the older generation's anxieties must also be considered.

Craft and conclusion: In a short form, the story presents the extensive social significance of time. The word chakra ('cycle') suggests the continuity of change. The story shows that the relationship between tradition and modernity is a subject for critical dialogue, not rigid opposition.

Drishtikon (Point of View)

Original pages: 82–88 | Principal characters or groups: Ranjana and Rakesh

The story's central question: Through the relationship between Ranjana and Rakesh, the narrative addresses prejudice surrounding marriage, love, respect and physical disability. The distance between external judgments and a person's actual qualities constitutes its central tension.

The character's decision: Ranjana's thinking does not mechanically reproduce social convention. The story develops the possibility of a humane outlook in which Rakesh's physical condition is not allowed to stand for the whole of his personhood.

Disability and dignity: It would be inappropriate to treat the story as a simple portrayal of pity. A person with a physical disability is equally entitled to full human dignity, love and the right to decide. From this perspective, the story criticises social prejudice. Ranjana's choice of relationship places human values first.

Critical discussion: The word drishtikon ('perspective') itself suggests that a problem may reside not simply in an object but also in the way it is seen. Through the characters, the author moves beyond a simple division between external incompleteness and internal completeness to consider the foundations of a respectful relationship.

Nirnay (Decision)

Original pages: 89–94 | Principal characters or groups: Ratan, Muna Bahin and Bhoji

Epistolary structure: The story's notable feature is its form as a letter. Through a letter addressed by Ratan to Muna Bahin, the family's circumstances, an accident, emotional responsibilities and the grounds for a future decision emerge. The narrative unfolds less through direct action than through remembrance and personal testimony.

The principal social question: Within a family crisis, the future of Bhoji comes into conflict with social conventions. Ratan's decision confronts established morality with the question of human responsibility. Its social significance lies in the recognition that the life of a family member cannot be made wholly subordinate to customary practice.

The effect of narrative form: The intimacy of address in the letter, recollections of experience and private reasoning bring the reader close to Ratan's inner conflict. An epistolary narrative, however, privileges the viewpoint of a single character. How clearly Bhoji's independent voice emerges remains a separate question for critical examination.

Evaluation: In Nirnay, the question of social courage is connected to an individual's responsibilities. The story does not merely reject conventional relationships; it seeks humane justice amid changing circumstances. The letter form makes the moral conflict effective.

Baate Bilayal Pani (Water Lost Along the Way)

Original pages: 95–99 | Principal characters or groups: Devki Babu, his children and Malti

Narrative: Devki Babu's old age and loneliness within the family form the basis of the story. As his children become absorbed in their separate lives, his emotional needs are neglected. The possibility of a relationship with Malti places companionship at the centre of an older person's life.

Human rights in old age: It is not enough to regard an older person merely as someone who needs accommodation and maintenance. The need for belonging, conversation, affection and independent decision-making persists to the end of life. Devki Babu's circumstances bring this truth into relief.

The social gaze: Society views the possibility of new companionship or remarriage in later life with suspicion. The story challenges this prejudice. The conflict between personal happiness and social acceptance becomes significant.

Title and critical conclusion: The title Baate Bilayal Pani suggests the flow of life and hopes gradually dissipating along the way. The story poses a far-reaching question: at what point does a person who has discharged familial duties lose the right to a life of their own? It is therefore an important work for the critical study of old age.

Aparajita (The Unvanquished)

Original pages: 100–104 | Principal characters or groups: Yashodhara and her familial and social environment

Narrative: Yashodhara's experiences of competition, difficulty, failure and renewed effort form the substance of the story. Despite recurrent obstacles, she refuses to surrender. Confidence develops through repeated attempts.

Implications of the title: Aparajita signifies not only someone who wins a competition but also someone who does not lose confidence in adversity. The title accords recognition to a quality of the protagonist's mind.

A woman's inner strength: Yashodhara's struggle shows that the aspiration to independence and respect is linked with personal effort. The importance of her endeavour lies not merely in winning social recognition but in the development of her own personality.

Meaning of the ending: As the final story in the collection, Aparajita gives the whole volume an optimistic tone. In response to the social barriers, pain and difficulties of decision-making presented in earlier stories, inner strength emerges as one possible answer. Yet individual success does not depend on personal effort alone: the part played by social opportunity and structural conditions must also be recognised.

Comparative Thematic Discussion of the Stories

Class, Labour and Social Standing

Reading Samay-Sanket and Paigh Lok together brings two forms of social standing into focus. The first presents an unequal distribution of power and rights; the second asks about the value of labour and human dignity. Sukhna comes to understand the meaning of his participation in the face of governmental or local dominance, while Preeta assesses what genuine greatness of conduct means within a wealthy environment. Both stories centre on the same question: how can human dignity be preserved independently of social status?

Marriage, Domestic Life and Women's Desires

In Gunanphal, Akanksha and Ahibatak Haar, the relationship between women's desires and social expectations in married life or the prospect of marriage is central. To treat marriage solely as a socially sanctioned institution suppresses the question of a woman's distinct personhood. Ahibatak Haar brings this tension into relief through cultural symbolism, while Gunanphal exposes the struggle between utility and dignity in the inner conduct of marriage. Akanksha clarifies the conflict between protection and freedom.

Self-Reliance and Inner Strength

Reading Dhuri and Aparajita together foregrounds women's capacity to face adversity. A sudden crisis awakens in Sheela the need for independence. Yashodhara's struggle establishes the importance of sustained effort and morale. The affirmative value of both stories is clear, but criticism must also ask how much social support and opportunity are available to enable an individual's efforts to bear fruit.

Old Age, Service and Human Relationships

Gulab Kaki and Baate Bilayal Pani depict different circumstances of old age. The first addresses neglect of an older woman and the need to belong; the second concerns an older man's entitlement to companionship and personal

happiness. Badla presents an ethical problem of service and compassion. The thread connecting these stories is that the existence of a family does not, in itself, guarantee sympathy. Respect for each person's experience is necessary to make relationships humane.

Changing Times, Values and Decisions

Yuddh and Kaal-Chakra portray the clash between generational experience and new ways of thinking. Nirnay takes the issue to the level of social convention and personal moral responsibility. Drishtikon reveals the role of prejudice in evaluating a person. In these stories, changing times mean not simply technological or economic developments but also the creation of new foundations for understanding relationships.

Narrative Craft and Linguistic Analysis

Plot and the Scale of the Stories

Many stories in the collection begin with a domestic incident or a familiar village episode and gradually arrive at a wider social question. Value-laden conclusions emerge through the characters' experiences. Some stories focus on a single small episode; others present several layers of relationship. The epistolary form of Nirnay is a particularly distinctive instance of the collection's formal variety.

The Function of Dialogue

The exchanges among Sukhna, Bilti and Master Saheb in Samay-Sanket, the generational dialogue in Yuddh, and the conversations expressing divergent viewpoints in Kaal-Chakra all contribute to the construction of meaning. Village speech and domestic address terms connect the characters to their society. Dialogue is not merely a means of conveying information; it also discloses social distance, intimacy and conflicts of value.

The Choice of Titles

The titles are both descriptive and suggestive. Gulab Kaki establishes intimacy through a person's name; Paigh Lok satirises a familiar social expression; Gunanphal turns a mathematical term into a question about relationships; and Yuddh, Dhuri, Kaal-Chakra and Samay-Sanket open up possibilities of metaphorical extension. The cultural expression Ahibatak Haar invokes a specifically Maithil marital context.

The Local Character of Maithili and the Author's Voice

The original book's language contains village and household practices, intimate forms of address, words from local life and the natural movement of dialogue. Terms such as 'paigh', 'kaki', 'Bilti' and 'ahibat' carry signs of cultural circumstance as well as lexical meaning. The analysis retains the original story and character names and the cultural terms. The critical prose of the source study, meanwhile, endeavours to use standard written Maithili so that the local quality of the stories' language is not effaced.

The Relationship between Narrative and Instruction

In some stories, the moral message emerges explicitly. This may also be regarded as a characteristic of the collection's social commitment. From the standpoint of literary criticism, however, clarity of thought and artistic enactment in a story are two distinct criteria. The present evaluation therefore attends not only to the ideas but also to the credibility of events, complexity of characters and possibility of multiple meanings in the narrative.

Feminist Criticism: Achievements and Contradictions

An important achievement of the collection is that the female characters are not confined to representing familial roles. They understand circumstances, endure suffering, ask questions and, at certain points, make their own decisions. The experiences of Preeta, Sheela, Meera, Chhavi, Amola, Ranjana and Yashodhara demonstrate women's capacity to determine the course of their lives in a variety of circumstances.

Nevertheless, the emphasis upon women's service, forgiveness and forbearance repeatedly raises a question: are men expected to possess these qualities to the same extent? The issue is especially important in reading Badla. Similarly, if a woman's self-reliance is treated solely as an achievement following crisis, inequalities of everyday opportunity, education and resources will remain obscured. Dhuri provides occasion for this further enquiry.

Feminist criticism should not assume that the circumstances of older women, economically dependent women, young unmarried women and married women are identical. Gulab Kaki's experience differs from Amola's in Ahibatak Haar. Respecting such differences reveals the breadth of the author's fictional world.

The collection's feminist dimension should consequently not be confined to slogans or one-dimensional opposition. It criticises tradition but also values familial intimacy; it insists upon women's independence while raising questions of responsibility and sympathy. Its intellectual complexity arises from these tensions.

Conclusion: Signs of the Times and an Unconquerable Sense of Life

The fourteen stories of Samay-Sanket present numerous layers of Maithil social life: working families in villages, conduct in prosperous households, internal imbalances within marriage, the loneliness of older people, young women's decisions about marriage, generational differences of outlook and inner strength in the face of adversity. Questions of human dignity and the just reconsideration of relationships lie at the centre of this diversity.

Viewed together, Sukhna's growing consciousness of his rights at the beginning and Yashodhara's self-confidence at the end yield two strands of collective and individual change. The former questions social structure; the latter offers a possibility of strength under adverse conditions. Between them, the stories describe life's difficult alternatives.

The author's importance lies in her ability to turn inequalities and sensitivities hidden within familiar social life into narratives. Original Maithili expression, domestic dialogue and social symbolism give the stories their regional identity. By preserving that identity, their human questions also acquire a wider significance for readers.

The final critical conclusion is that the collection is a literary exploration of the desire for change and the reassessment of relationships. Its characters are neither wholly ideal nor wholly culpable; they are human beings seeking meaning amid changing social circumstances. Appropriate criticism must acknowledge this complexity.

Principal Findings of the Study

1. Although the fourteen stories portray different situations in life, they are connected by questions of human dignity and social change.

2. Women's self-determination, education, economic independence and rights concerning marriage recur throughout the collection.

3. Criticism of conventional measures of social standing is particularly pronounced in Samay-Sanket and Paigh Lok.

4. The critical treatment of old age is developed through both male and female characters; maintenance alone is insufficient, for affection and companionship are also necessary.

5. The story titles are frequently more than simple names for events: they signal broader symbols or critical questions.

6. The epistolary Nirnay introduces formal variety into the collection's modes of narration.

7. In evaluating the feminist significance of the stories, attention must also be paid to the possible tension between glorifying women's sacrifice and affirming women's freedom.

8. The original book's language and social forms of address place its characters within distinctively Maithil circumstances.

Chapter 3: A Maithili Vocabulary of Dress, Costume and Adornment

Primary work: Dr Kamla Chaudhary, Maithilīk Vesh-Bhūshā-Prasādhan Sambandhī Shabdāvalī, 2008.

The Scope of the Work and the Critical Perspective

Dr Kamla Chaudhary's book addresses a particular field of interaction between language and folk culture: Maithili words associated with clothing worn upon the body, ornaments and materials for personal adornment. The word shabdavali ('vocabulary') in the title is important. The author moves beyond a mere inventory of garments towards the analysis of naming, semantic change, established usage and representation in literature.

The sequence of the contents itself proposes an argument: first the Indian tradition, followed by the Maithil tradition, then historical change; next the

evidence of ancient, medieval and modern Maithili literature; and finally lexicographical classification and linguistic analysis. In this structure, cultural history and linguistics form two mutually complementary foundations.

An Outline of the Original Work's Twelve Chapters

Chapter	Subject	First printed page
1	Indian traditions of dress and adornment	1
2	Maithil traditions of dress and adornment	34
3	Influences upon Maithil tradition and resulting changes	61
4	Dress and adornment in ancient Maithili literature	67
5	Dress and adornment in medieval Maithili literature	94
6	Dress and adornment in modern Maithili literature	153
7	Vocabulary of dress	272
8	Vocabulary of ornaments	292
9	Vocabulary of cosmetics and adornment	302
10	Phonological analysis	310
11	Lexical analysis	316
12	The study of prefixes and suffixes	324

Chapter One: Indian Traditions of Dress and Adornment

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 1 and extends to page 33, immediately before the following chapter (as indicated by the table of contents).

The discussion of Indian tradition serves as an introduction situating the Maithili lexicon within a broader civilisational setting. Dress and adornment are not simply objects of aesthetic appreciation; they are signs bearing meanings associated with social decorum, season, occasion, community practices and religious observances. Without this background, it is difficult to understand the full meanings of local terms.

In establishing relationships between Indian sources and local words of Mithila, a distinction is needed between resemblance of form and genuine historical connection. Finding the name of a garment in Sanskrit or another early text does not, by itself, prove its uninterrupted use in Maithili. Intermediate periods, changes of form, semantic development and evidence of spoken use all need to be considered.

From a critical standpoint, the usefulness of this chapter lies in providing a comparative basis. Yet Indian clothing has never been wholly uniform: variations arise from region, materials, techniques of manufacture and social class. Local particularities should not be dissolved by treating the 'Indian' context as a universal rule.

The research questions arising from this chapter are these: which words originate in a broad Indian tradition, which forms develop particular meanings in Maithili, and which objects are understood differently in various regions under the same name? Questions of this kind make the historical study of vocabulary accountable to evidence.

Chapter Two: Maithil Traditions of Dress and Adornment

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 34 and extends to page 60, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The focus now shifts from general Indian practice to the specific character of Maithil social life. Local forms of dress, the practices of adornment among women and men, social rites, occasions such as weddings, available materials and customary names are interrelated. These relationships provide the key to understanding the vocabulary.

It would be inappropriate to treat 'old' and 'new' as invariably opposed categories in explaining Maithil tradition. A name for an item of clothing may continue even as its construction, fibre, manner of wearing or circumstances of use change. Conversely, new materials may impart fresh meanings to established local words.

Folk memory and written evidence should be weighed separately. A name preserved in an older speaker's memory is extremely valuable, but its date must be checked against other evidence. Recording regional distinctions—north and south, town and village, and linguistic contact along border areas—would further broaden this research.

The chapter's principal achievement is to establish the material culture of the Maithil body as a legitimate subject of linguistic study. The history of a language is not only the history of literary style; domestic practices, garment names and methods of ornamentation are also part of its living archive.

Chapter Three: Influences upon Maithil Tradition and the Changes They Produced

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 61 and extends to page 66, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The existence of a separate chapter on this subject is significant. Tradition is not a static object but a social process affected by contact, trade, politics, education, transport and changes in modes of production. Changes in vocabulary must be understood within this mobile context.

New forms of clothing and jewellery may bring new names. Sometimes an outside word is adopted in full; sometimes it acquires a local phonetic form; and sometimes an existing word comes to denote a new object. These are processes of lexical borrowing, semantic extension and renaming in linguistics.

To understand changes in clothing merely as the 'decline of tradition' would restrict the analysis. Changes in convenience, cost, the gendered division of labour, availability and taste alter social functions. Traditional dress may persist in wedding rituals while newer garments come into everyday use during the same period.

At the level of criticism, the direction, duration and channels of influence could be classified more systematically in this chapter. Internal developments within Mithila, contact with neighbouring languages and the introduction of distant industrial products are not identical processes.

Chapter Four: Dress and Adornment Described in Ancient Maithili Literature

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 67 and extends to page 93, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The use of literary evidence is central to the methodological importance of the work. Terms relating to clothing in poetry or early written texts demonstrate historical word forms and cultural imagination. The language of poetry, however, is not a direct statistical record of actual daily practices.

The occurrence of a word can provide three kinds of evidence: the existence of a name for an object, its figurative or ornamental meaning, or the values of the period. A reference to jewellery, for instance, may signify beauty, status or emotion rather than merely the physical object. Meaning cannot be established without reading the context.

In examining this literary chapter, the date of composition, available textual editions, linguistic form and accuracy of quotations are decisive. It can be misleading to treat the spelling of a later editor as phonetic evidence from the original period. The complete line surrounding each term, together with source references, would make the enquiry reproducible.

The effort to trace survivals of ancient terms in present-day speech is useful, but similarity of sound alone does not establish continuity of meaning.

Comparison of an object's actual construction with its contemporary meaning is a promising direction in which the chapter could be developed.

Chapter Five: Dress and Adornment Described in Medieval Maithili Literature

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 94 and extends to page 152, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The considerable space devoted to medieval literature indicates a particular interest in historical lexical evidence. Poetry may bring clothing, adornment, bodily ornamentation and elaborate metaphors into simultaneous view. Contexts such as the description of a heroine, social appearance and religious feeling produce differences in meaning.

In studying the poetry of this period, symbolic language must be distinguished from actual dress. An ornament in a poem may express devotional or erotic feeling; it does not thereby establish the everyday clothing practices of every woman or man in society.

Questions of textual variants, manuscript traditions and editorial standardisation are relevant to the history of Maithili literature. Where a word occurs in different forms across texts, relationships among variant form, pronunciation and meaning should be recorded with their uncertainty intact.

The research value of this chapter resides in comparing the chronological occurrence of words with their literary use. A consistent analytical sequence can be constructed around the term, literary work, period, meaning, formal variants and present-day usage.

Chapter Six: Dress and Adornment Described in Modern Maithili Literature

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 153 and extends to page 271, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

According to the contents, the chapter on modern literature is among the most extensive sections of the book. Its length itself suggests that the language of local clothing in modern fiction, poetry and other literary genres provides rich material for comparative study.

In modern writing, words for clothing and adornment may signal a character's economic circumstances, caste standing, generational difference, gendered expectations, participation in a festival or experience of displacement. Literary descriptions may be ironic, reminiscent or realistic. Dictionary definitions therefore remain incomplete without an understanding of their textual settings.

Modern consumer culture and changing production systems may add new categories to the lexicon. Nevertheless, this broad historical observation cannot be treated as a direct conclusion about any particular author or quotation in the book. Each specific example requires verification against the original text.

A critique of this chapter raises the problem of literary representativeness. The world of characters in literature is not a statistical sample of Mithila as a whole. Unequal representation of town and village, social class, gender and historical periods may affect the frequency of terms in a lexical collection.

The importance of this section lies in completing the historical triad—ancient, medieval and modern. To test the relationships among the three chapters scientifically, evidence-based markers such as 'earliest attested written use' and 'latest attested use' of a particular item would be useful.

Chapter Seven: The Vocabulary of Dress

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 272 and extends to page 291, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

According to the contents, this chapter marks the book's movement from descriptive history towards direct lexicography. Printed pages 286–287, which were examined, contain names of garments and definitions concerning their construction, shape, use or manner of wearing them upon the body. This distinguishes the passage from a lifeless catalogue of names.

Among the words and variants visible in this part of the original are ‘पायजामा/पजामा’ (payjama/pajama), ‘मोहरी’ (mohari), ‘पेट’ (pet), ‘साड़ी’ (sari), ‘नुआ/लुगा’ (nua/luga) and ‘आँचर’ (anchar). They are presented here only as directly observed examples; no claim is made that any of them bears the same meaning everywhere.

The description of the sari in particular suggests relations among the garment's sections, their location on the body and local naming practices. A word such as ‘आँचर’ (anchar), though it names a specific part of a garment, may acquire additional meanings through social usage. A lexicon is enhanced by relating names for parts of objects to associated actions and social contexts.

For a critical study of this chapter, a functional classification of clothing—upper garments, lower garments, coverings, stitched and unstitched clothing, use by men, women or both, and special occasions—would be useful. This is an analytical proposal by the researcher, not a verified sequence encompassing every entry in the original book.

Chapter Eight: The Vocabulary of Ornaments

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 292 and extends to page 301, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The vocabulary of jewellery and ornaments provides an opportunity to consider the physical construction of an object alongside its social and symbolic meanings. Classification by the part of the body—ear, nose, neck, upper arm, hand, waist and foot—often clarifies the organisation of meaning.

A lexical study of ornaments should separately record metals, gems, construction, use in pairs or singly, association with marriage or other rituals,

and variations in local names. A change in the size or material of an object may alter its designation, while the same name may apply to several forms.

Questions of gender and marital status form an important cultural concern associated with this chapter. It would, however, be an ahistorical generalisation to assume that a particular ornament has had one compulsory social significance across all the communities and periods of Mithila.

From a lexicographical standpoint, illustrations of ornaments, their placement on the body, synonyms, regional alternatives and verified literary quotations would make this chapter more effective as an archive of folk culture.

Chapter Nine: The Vocabulary of Cosmetics and Adornment

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 302 and extends to page 309, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The domain of personal adornment differs somewhat from clothing and jewellery. It brings together the materials and practices of decorating the body, applying substances, arranging hair, using fragrances and other forms of ornamentation. One word may name a material, another the act of applying it or the appropriate occasion for doing so.

For words of this kind, the boundary between physical substance and social meaning is often permeable. The same item may acquire different meanings in the contexts of daily hygiene, beauty, ritual or health. A single-line synonym is therefore not always sufficient.

The relationship between traditional folk cosmetics and new commercially available materials can be connected with linguistic change. Establishing the date of introduction of any particular product, however, requires additional historical evidence; the present critique does not supply dates unsupported by sources.

Future research arising from this chapter would benefit from separate descriptions of types of substance, methods of preparation, user groups, occasions, restrictions and their presence in folk songs.

Chapter Ten: Phonological Analysis

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 310 and extends to page 315, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The inclusion of phonological analysis means that this is more than a cultural word list: it makes a claim to linguistic investigation. Terms associated with dress and adornment may undergo changes of pronunciation across time and region.

A linguistic investigation must distinguish the root form, actual pronunciation, phonetic shifts, vowel changes, consonant simplification and forms resulting from language contact. Orthographic variation is not the

same as phonetic variation: different written forms must not automatically be taken as evidence of different pronunciations.

Resemblance of form alone is insufficient to establish a word's etymology. Historical intermediate forms, correspondence of meaning and identifiable phonological rules are required. Re-examination according to these criteria could increase the usefulness of the book's linguistic contribution.

In evaluating this chapter, it would be useful to record separately the place of pronunciation, speakers' generations, social settings and the conventional spellings of written literature.

Chapter Eleven: Lexical Analysis

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 316 and extends to page 323, immediately before the next chapter (according to the table of contents).

The study of words encompasses their formation, structure, classification, meanings and relationships. The overall plan of this book raises a particular question: which names for objects have local origins, which have entered through other linguistic traditions, and which have developed multiple meanings?

Multiple names for the same object, or the use of the same name for several objects, demonstrate the practical character of a vocabulary. Under these conditions, the analysis of synonymy, semantic narrowing, semantic extension and the formation of names is not merely the accumulation of lexical material; it is also an enquiry into semantics.

From a critical perspective, the minimum essential elements of each entry might be considered to include the headword, grammatical class, clear definition, example, distinguishing boundaries, current usage and supporting source. This is a proposed lexicographical standard, not a claim that every entry in the original work meets these requirements.

The chapter is relevant because of its potential to connect objects of everyday life with the semantic organisation of language. Comparison with vocabularies of other social domains may clarify general tendencies in Maithili word formation.

Chapter Twelve: The Study of Prefixes and Suffixes

In the original work, this chapter begins on printed page 324 and extends to page 340, immediately before the following section (according to the table of contents).

The final chapter examines the morphological means of forming words. The creation of new terms through prefixes and suffixes offers an appropriate field for the structural study of vocabulary associated with clothing and adornment.

Semantic analysis must determine whether a given form is genuinely a productive suffix or simply an inseparable part of an older word. Before

treating a form borrowed from a contact language as a Maithili suffix, evidence is needed from independent examples, frequency and phonological adaptation.

A parallel presentation of base words, derived forms, grammatical categories, changes in meaning and attested usage would be useful in evaluating this chapter. Such a method could yield a coherent account of word formation, rather than merely a list of forms.

The order of phonology, lexicon and then prefixes and suffixes in the book is meaningful from a linguistic standpoint. Here the cultural vocabulary and grammatical analysis enter into the same study.

A Critical Reading of the Conclusion (from Printed Page 341)

The original book provides a separate 'Conclusion'. In view of the entire contents, the wider contribution of the research lies in bringing Maithili literature, the material culture of everyday life and linguistic analysis of vocabulary into a shared field of enquiry.

To treat the book merely as a list of names threatened with disappearance would be to limit its potential. It is important as an attempt to combine the definition of words in their cultural contexts, the collection of literary evidence and the analysis of form. Nevertheless, verification of textual sources, standardised citation and the identification of regions of use require separate, more detailed scrutiny.

A Study of the Appendices

Appendix (a): List of Words — Printed Page 345

According to the contents, the original book concludes with a list of additional words collected after the main text had been completed. This is editorially significant: a lexical collection is not a fixed and final inventory but a process that can continue to grow with research and regional dialogue. To incorporate these words into a final dictionary, their forms, meanings, supporting evidence and areas of use should be recorded.

Appendix (b): Reference Bibliography — Printed Page 351

A reference bibliography is a primary means of testing historical claims, poetic quotations, etymologies and descriptions of society and culture. The original list has not been reproduced verbatim in the present discussion; accordingly, no additional work has been falsely attributed to the author of the source.

Appendix (c): 'List of Erroneous Books' — Printed Page 354

The third appendix is named 'Ashuddhi Granthak Suchi' ('List of Erroneous Books') in the original table of contents. This title is reproduced from that list; without closer confirmation of its intended meaning or the form of its entries, it has not been silently converted into an ordinary 'List of Corrections'. Preserving the distinction is an essential condition of source-faithful textual editing.

A Close Reading of Terms Relating to Dress

On the two pages concerning dress vocabulary, the discussion of 'पायजामा/पजामा' (payjama/pajama) includes details of its construction and manner of wearing; 'मोहरी' (mohari) denotes a lower section; and 'साड़ी' (sari) and 'नुआ/लुगा' (nua/luga) are also discussed. The influence of local usage on the forms of words becomes apparent.

In the discussion of the sari, there is an account of its front, back and upper parts, and sections relating to its length. 'आँचर' (anchar) appears in this context as well. This is an important lexicographical method: the names of an object's parts, its uses and associated actions can be examined within a single semantic field.

The examples on these pages disclose at least four levels of linguistic structure: (1) the main name of the object, (2) alternative local forms, (3) names for its constituent parts, and (4) verbal descriptions of the manner of wearing it. Separate indexing of these four levels would make the research more searchable.

Integrated Critical Conclusions

1. This book connects the study of Maithil clothing culture with vocabulary and literary history. It would therefore be inappropriate to confine it either to a narrow ethnographic category or to lexicography alone.

2. The sequence of twelve chapters extends from a broad Indian background through Maithil particularities, historical change and chronological literary evidence to the lexical collection and linguistic analysis.

3. Dress, jewellery and cosmetics are not synonymous domains. Clear subcategories are needed on the basis of practical use, relations to the body and social symbolism.

4. The lexical material directly examined in the original work includes significant regional variants and names for parts of objects. These demonstrate the richness of Maithili lexicography.

5. Descriptions of dress in poetry should not be treated as results of a social census. The genre, context and textual variants of every literary example should be checked.

6. Claims concerning historical continuity, external influences, etymology and use within particular communities need not all meet an identical evidentiary standard. Each kind of claim requires its own class of evidence.

7. In a future scholarly edition, each entry should be accompanied by clear markers of printed page, quotation, variant form, meaning, class of object, region, literary period and source verification.

General Conclusion

The diversity of Kamla Chaudhary's writing becomes apparent across these three works. In Monak Pauti, the translator imaginatively enters another writer's consciousness, establishing a dialogue between language and experience. In Samay-Sanket, the storyteller's vision focuses upon social inequality, interpersonal relationships and the ethics of decision-making. In A Maithili Vocabulary of Dress, Costume and Adornment, the material history of cultural life is preserved in the form of words.

Shashitara in Monak Pauti and many of the female characters in Samay-Sanket raise a shared question: how can an individual preserve her desires, rights and dignity beyond the roles sanctioned by society? Yet the former is a translated novella and the latter an original collection of stories. To place them side by side while effacing the differences in their narrative methods and authorial responsibility would be a critical error.

The lexicographical investigation of dress and adornment opens a different perspective upon this question. Names for the clothes, jewellery, personal adornments and social practices of women and men are not merely names of material objects; they also indicate history, status, taste and relationships. Cultural terms that appear naturally in fiction and translation can be examined in the vocabulary work through their semantic development and inherited usage.

Connecting these three directions, an intimacy with everyday life in the Maithili language, the assertion of women's personhood, diversity of social conduct and vitality of literary craft emerge as major characteristics of Kamla Chaudhary's work. Rather than pronouncing a final judgment, this volume offers readers a systematic basis for enquiry in which fiction, translation, and the questions of language and culture illuminate one another.

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D. Bibliographical Note

The relationship between the printed Bengali editions, dates and publishers associated with the title Moner Jhanpi in the publication details of Monak Pauti and the title Sonar Kouto examined comparatively here has not been established. No separate bibliographical entry has therefore been invented for an unverified Bengali edition. Likewise, the names of the publishers of Samay-Sanket and Maithilīk Vesh-Bhūshā-Prasādhan Sambandhī Shabdāvalī have not been supplied without confirmation.

STUDY 04 / NIT NAVAL

Vrishesh Chandra Lal

1. Andolan (Movement)

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Poetry Collection Andolan: A Close Literary-Historical Study of Contemporary Political Consciousness, Political Regression and Democratic Discourse

Original work	Andolan — a collection of Maithili poetry
Author / poet	Vrishesh Chandra Lal
Genre	Maithili poetry collection
Publisher	Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham
Publication context	Vikram Samvat 2061; the historical background of Nepal's political crisis of 2002–04 and the movement against political regression
Price	NPR 15 / INR 10
Dedication	To martyrs and great souls who sacrificed themselves for the public good
Preface	Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal" (Devithan, Janakpurdham)

Introduction

Literature is not merely a mirror of society; it is also among the most authentic records of an age's pulse, its political upheavals and its human struggles. To understand the history of any period, political essays, government documents and a chronology of historical events are necessary. Yet to experience the genuine suffering, anger and hopes of ordinary people, the literature of that period is indispensable. In the words of the eminent Maithili critic Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal," "Poetry, or literature, has been called the articulate sibling of silent history." In this wider context, Andolan, a collection of Maithili poems by the senior politician and writer Vrishesh Chandra Lal, composed against the background of Nepal's contemporary political history—particularly its democratic struggle, royal regression and popular movements—is regarded as a historical, intellectual and literary milestone.

Published by Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham, the collection was given a highly symbolic price—15 Nepalese rupees and 10 Indian rupees. This suggests that the book's primary purpose was not commercial profit but the dissemination of democratic consciousness and the message of resistance to regression among the people. Its dedication honours all the known and unknown martyrs and great souls who sacrificed their lives for the public good

and in defence of democracy. From the outset, the dedication reveals the revolutionary, people-centred ethos of the work and its profound regard for sacrifice.

The title Andolan, or "Movement," simultaneously opens up three dimensions: action, condition and history. It signifies not simply a particular political programme, but movement against inertia, resistance against fear, and an insistence upon popular rights against a society organised around power. The collection was published by Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham. A university bibliography gives its publication year as Vikram Samvat 2061, corresponding to 2004–05 CE. During this period Nepal was passing through a severe political crisis marked by the dissolution of its elected parliament, royal intervention, the Maoist armed conflict and the anti-regression protests of democratic parties.

The dedication page establishes the book's moral register in advance: it is dedicated to martyrs and great souls who endured "the pain of sacrifice for the public good." The significance of this statement is not confined to a sentimental tribute. In the poems that follow, the poet repeatedly asks who enjoys the fruits of sacrifice, who bears the suffering, who acquires the prestige of leadership, and where the people stand in all this. Thus the dedication and the satire of "Chalu Andolanme!" ("Come, Let Us Join the Movement!") are not opposed to one another. They are two ends of the same moral question: genuine sacrifice versus the political trade in sacrifice.

In his preface, Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal" speaks of poetry as "the articulate sibling of history" and regards each poem in the collection as a "vigorous document" of the Nepal of its time. Yet the literary value of the book is not confined to documentary testimony. News ceases to be news, and political circumstances change. Poetry endures when it rises above immediate events and becomes an enduring inquiry into power, fear, opportunism, the crowd, the hero, popular rights, nationhood and development. The strongest poems in Andolan achieve precisely this elevation.

The Writer's Personality, Political Background and Literary Endeavour

The poet Vrishesh Chandra Lal was born on 29 March 1955 (16 Chaitra 2011 in the Nepali calendar). His life has been devoted to the continuing struggle for democracy, social justice and the rights of Madhesh in Nepal. He is a prominent figure in Nepal's democratic movement, a former member of the National Assembly (2017–19), and a former head (mayor) of Janakpur Municipality.

A study of his political journey is indispensable to an understanding of this poetry collection. Initially he was a committed political follower of Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala (B. P. Koirala), Nepal's first democratically elected prime minister and a major literary figure, and for many years he was active in the politics of the Nepali Congress. B. P. Koirala's principles of democratic socialism, national reconciliation and human freedom remained the foundations of Vrishesh Chandra Lal's intellectual outlook. Later, seeking to

respond to the aspirations of the Madhesh movement and disillusioned with the centralising mentality of the state, he left the Nepali Congress in 2007 along with Mahantha Thakur and played a leading role in founding the Tarai Madhesh Loktantrik Party (TMLP). Subsequently, after playing an important role in the Loktantrik Samajwadi Party (LSP), he decided to revive the TMLP in protest against the working methods of its president, Mahantha Thakur, and the neglect of the essential concerns of the Madhesh movement. This entire succession of political advances and reversals demonstrates that Vrishesh Chandra Lal is not a poet who imagines the world from an air-conditioned room; he is a realist writer formed among the streets, political movements and ordinary people. In 2018 the well-known Mithila Natya Kala Parishad (MINAP) of Janakpur also conferred on him the title of "Mahamurkh" at its Mahamurkh Sammelan, a recognition indicative of his acceptance within social and cultural life.

Although political responsibilities have left him insufficient time for literary creation, the works he has produced constitute an invaluable resource for Maithili literature. His Maithili adaptation of Modiaain, the celebrated psychological novel by Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala; his original collection of stories Malho; and an intellectual work such as Sanghiyatak Sambandhme ("On Federalism") attest to his literary and intellectual depth. Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal" observes that Lal's personality has been marked since childhood by emotion, sensitivity, reflection, an awareness of the historical moment and an acute political consciousness. Because he dedicated the greater part of his energies to establishing democracy, however, the literary world has received only a small portion of the gifts of his talent. Nevertheless, the surge of feeling, rhetorical force, imagery and unflinching depiction of reality in Andolan offer irrefutable evidence of his poetic gifts, much of which had hitherto remained unseen.

Principal aspects of Vrishesh Chandra Lal's life and work	Description and historical significance
Birth and early influences	29 March 1955; profoundly influenced by B. P. Koirala's democratic socialism.
Political career	Former mayor of Janakpur, former member of the National Assembly (2017–19), founding leader of the TMLP.
Ideological evolution	Nepali Congress (until 2007), followed by leadership in the TMLP, LSP and the revived TMLP in pursuit of Madhesh rights.
Literary contribution	Andolan (poetry collection), Malho (short-story collection), Modiaain (Maithili translation), Sanghiyatak Sambandhme (translation / critical discussion).

Political vocabulary in Andolan therefore never feels ornamental. “Power,” “people,” “nationality,” “republic,” “peace,” “struggle” and “sacrifice” may be abstract nouns, but the poet connects them with bodies, hunger, batons, blood, streets, darkness, drums, grinding stones, rooms and soil. Political thought is transformed successfully into poetry when an idea becomes a scene; this quality is particularly strong in Lal’s finest lines.

Historical and Political Background: Royal Regression and the People’s Movement

An authentic evaluation of revolutionary literature is impossible without reference to the historical context in which it was composed. The creative circumstances of Andolan are bound up with one of the most tragic, unstable and decisive periods in Nepal’s contemporary history, Vikram Samvat 2059–63. The process by which democratic institutions in Nepal were systematically dismantled culminated in King Gyanendra’s royal coup. The dissolution of the House of Representatives by the then prime minister in Jeth 2059 (May 2002), the subsequent removal of the elected prime minister in Asoj 2059 (October 2002), and finally the direct royal takeover by King Gyanendra on 19 Magh 2061 (1 February 2005) brought Nepal’s democratic system to the point of collapse.

Without understanding Nepal in Vikram Samvat 2061, it is difficult to grasp the full poetic intensity of Andolan. Parliament was dissolved in May 2002. In October 2002 King Gyanendra removed Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba and assumed executive authority himself; elections remained suspended and the process of elected representation became uncertain. By 2003–04, the country faced a combined crisis of royally appointed governments, Maoist violence, a security policy centred on the army and pressure on civil liberties. Human-rights reports document widespread repression of the anti-regression demonstrations organised by five political parties in April 2004. The reverberations of this atmosphere can clearly be heard in the collection’s images of darkness, ghosts, guns, batons, swindlers, terror, blood and resistance.

For these historical reasons, it would be inappropriate to read the collection retrospectively through the outcomes of the later Madhesh movement of 2007 or the establishment of the republic in 2008. The poet subsequently played an important public role in Madhesh politics and the debate on federalism. But the immediate historical moment of Andolan was principally one of crisis in parliamentary democracy, royal regression and questions concerning the credibility of political parties. This distinction in chronology is essential; otherwise, the poet’s later political identity may be imposed upon the meanings of the original poems.

One interpretation associates the immediate context of the collection’s composition with the dissolution of the House of Representatives in 2020. But because the book’s publication year is given as Vikram Samvat 2061, this view does not accord with the chronology of its publication. It is therefore more consistent to locate the collection’s original historical setting in the

parliamentary crisis of 2002–04, royal intervention, Maoist conflict and the anti-regression movement.

During this period Nepal was caught in a terrifying cycle: military repression by the state on one side and the Maoist armed conflict on the other. Fundamental civil rights were suspended, the media were subjected to stringent censorship, journalists and political activists who voiced independent opinions were imprisoned, and a pervasive atmosphere of terror, murder and fear prevailed. Against this authoritarianism and the conspiracies of political regression, an alliance of seven parliamentary parties, civil society and the general public took to the streets and sounded the call for mass mobilisation. This movement ultimately opened the way to the historic second People's Movement of 2062–63, the end of the 240-year-old monarchy and the establishment of a democratic republic in Nepal.

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's poetry collection is a living poetic document of the cry from those very streets, of the consciousness of protest, of citizens' indomitable courage and of intellectual resistance to authoritarianism. While parliamentary forces confronted the seemingly dead cobra of regression, now rushing forward with spears and farm implements, Lal's pen was giving that struggle its words.

The Critical Significance of Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal"'s Preface

The preface lends this book further authenticity and historical weight. It was written by Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal," an eminent critic, linguist and academic in Maithili and Nepali literature. Born in 2004 Vikram Samvat in Devdiha (Khirakhiriya), Dhanusha, and holding a doctorate in linguistics from Banaras Hindu University, Vimal is a distinguished figure in Nepalese letters. He writes with equal command in Nepali and Maithili and has expressed forceful views on social contradictions, human sensibility and questions of nationality.

Dr Vimal contributes a deeply moving essay entitled "This Gold of Poetry Emerging from the Fire of the Movement..." His principal propositions may be set out as follows. First, he regards literature as the articulate sibling of silent history. Just as every petal of a flower tells of its soil, water and light, so poetry expresses the laughter and tears, anger and agitation experienced by its creator. Second, he asserts that, for the first time in Nepalese Maithili literature, a poetry collection has appeared in which every poem is inspired exclusively by contemporary politics and the democratic struggle. The claim is significant because Maithili literature has traditionally been more concerned with love, devotion and social or cultural reform, as in the tradition of Vidyapati or the campaign against child marriage. A complete collection devoted solely to political poetry of resistance was rare. Third, Dr Vimal calls Lal a poet endowed with a vision of his time. The book reveals the tenderly sensitive yet fire-breathing poet concealed within a politician.

The writer of the preface also describes the political landscape of the period in highly figurative language. Following the dissolution of parliament, "the

forces of regression are hissing—as though a dead cobra had come back to life and spread its hood"; meanwhile, "the parliamentary forces are running towards it with spears and farm implements, piercing it all over, yet it repeatedly lunges to bite." Such animal imagery—the dead snake, the cobra—vividly renders the prospect of political resurgence and the impulse towards retaliation, and closely resembles the figurative method of the poet himself.

Thematic, Philosophical and Formal Analysis of the Poems in Andolan

The collection contains twelve political and philosophical poems of lasting significance. They may be broadly divided into five major thematic groups and subjected to close and detailed analysis.

1. The Symbolic Representation of Political Regression and the Appeal for Ideological Leadership

The collection's first poem, "Aabah Na!" ("Do Come!"; p. 7), is both an attack upon the regressive political power of the time in Nepal and an impassioned appeal to the poet's ideological mentor, B. P. Koirala. The poet depicts political regression as a "ghost." In the folktales of Mithila, ghosts are often imagined with feet turned backwards and an appetite for blood. Lal transforms this familiar folkloric image into a powerful political symbol:

"B. P., into your village / a ghost has entered / that walks backwards! / Its feet are turned the wrong way, towards the rear; / blood is still caked upon its teeth; / even the reflection of its face in water appears deathly; / with its eyes and ears turned towards its back, / it looks backwards, it thinks backwards!!"

Here "feet turned backwards" and "thinking backwards" become exact emblems of a monarchic inclination to drive an advancing society back towards autocracy and feudalism. "Blood on its teeth" signifies state terror and the killing of innocent citizens. The poet fears that even the bhagat—the ritual healer or exorcist expected to free society from this ghost—may join forces with it. The image satirises opportunistic leaders who surrender to power by making their peace with the royal court. What is needed, therefore, is a committed revolutionary vision such as B. P. Koirala's.

The second poem, "Katta Chhi, Aaune!" ("Where Are You? Come!"; p. 8), likewise searches for a genuine guide in this time of darkness.

"In every lane, armed men / are roaming about; / in the name of protection, swindlers / are plundering everything."

The poem movingly shows how a society loses its bearings when the state ceases to protect and begins to prey upon its citizens, while armed men—security personnel or insurgents, evoked by the colloquial expression tikba—terrorise ordinary people. It represents the extreme reality of civilian insecurity during a period of crisis.

The poem calls upon B. P. Koirala's historical presence almost in the role of a bhagat, an exorcist summoned to drive away the ghost. Devotion and irony are interwoven here. On one hand the poet seeks a moral guardian of democratic ideals; on the other, the failure of contemporary political

leadership becomes self-evident. If a dead leader must be called back, what does that say about the living leadership? The poem does not answer the question directly, but its dramatic structure leaves behind a question sharper than any ready-made answer.

"Katta Chhi, Aaune!" is almost a brief political monologue. Armed men in every lane, plunder in the guise of protection, and the absence of anyone to show the way together create a picture of public insecurity and moral anarchy. The line "Kannekke Baat Dekhaune" ("Show us the way, if only a little") discloses a central aspiration of the collection: poetry does not supply a prefabricated map, but seeks the public judgment capable of indicating a path. The question of this "path" reappears ironically in "Road Map," where a diagram comes to rule in place of the actual road.

2. State Terror, Hollow Peace and Incisive Satire on Autocracy

When a ruling class attempts to silence the people at gunpoint, it calls the result "peace." In "Shanti Chahi Muda Pharma Bamojim" ("We Want Peace, but According to the Mould"; p. 9), the poet mocks this imposed "negative peace"—the silence of the cremation ground:

"Hey, you makers of peace, / manufacture peace according to the mould. / This is the land of the Gorkhalis! / Without quarrels, scuffles and sorrow, / without weapons, khukuris and sharp points, / life here has no vitality; / here, violence must be fitted into peace."

Through the phrase "land of the Gorkhalis," the poet delivers a severe criticism of the Nepalese state structure, dominated, in this reading, by militarism and the arrogance of a single ethnic identity. Nepal's centralised authority has persistently trusted displays of force. Even the ruler's peace is fashioned "according to the mould"—cast in a predetermined pattern in which violence is indispensable. The lines also articulate the disquiet of Madheshi and other marginalised communities that have long been regarded with suspicion by the state.

Among the collection's sharpest and most forcefully satirical poems is "Durrar Baklel!" ("Away, You Fool!"; pp. 10–12), which portrays the rulers' insatiable greed, hypocrisy and repression of the people across four sections. The ruling class demands peace, revolution, renunciation, order and even heaven—but demands them exclusively for itself:

"We want labour, we want struggle; / we want renunciation and sacrifice; / we want the finest offering; / we want heaven here on earth. / What do we not want? We want everything. / But do you think it is for you? / Away, you fool! / We do want it, yessss— / but for ourselves!!"

In the second section the ruler orders the people to remain silent: "When I speak, be quiet; / when I play games, be quiet; / when I press you hard, be quiet … / when you sleep hungry, be quiet; / when you are cut down, be quiet; / when you die before my eyes, be quiet; / that is what real peace means." The passage exposes the extremity of feudal inhumanity: even the people's deaths

must take place without a sound, so that the ruler's supposed "peace" remains undisturbed.

The third section lays bare the ruler's conceit: "I am the state; let it bear my name; / bring all the subjects here to me." This is the naked feudal arrogance associated with the French monarch Louis XIV's "L'État, c'est moi" ("I am the state"). It sees the people not as citizens but merely as raiyats—subjects or dependants. The poem is thus a psychological examination of autocracy.

A line such as "This is the land of the Gorkhalis" should not be taken as a literal ethnic conclusion. The entire poem operates through hyperbolic satire: it ridicules the reasoning that treats a tradition of violence as an innate national disposition and therefore finds it necessary to insert violence even into peace. What the poem actually criticises is the mentality that normalises violence, and declares it necessary, in the names of vitality, celebration, valour or nationhood.

In the second section, commands such as "When I speak, be quiet," "When I eat, be quiet" and "When you sleep hungry, be quiet" capture the one-way orders of authoritarian government. Their simplicity is formally effective, since power reveals its ideology not only in grand speeches but in everyday imperatives. In the third section, "Let the people say whatever I think" presents representation turned upside down: the people are not to think for themselves; they must utter what the ruler thinks. The poet strikes here at a counterfeit democracy in which leadership hears its own echo in the name of the people.

In the fifth section, the poet targets communal and identity-based politics: "If you are Hindu, wave the ceremonial fly-whisk; if you are Buddhist, perform the samyak … if you are Mugurali, enlarge your turban." The passage delivers a pointed comment on vote-bank politics conducted in the names of religious communities. Taken as a whole, the poem becomes a comprehensive, pictorial indictment of the opportunism of Nepal's political class.

8. "Ee Andolan Dekha Det": The Direction of History and Resistance to Regression

In this poem, the movement embodies the forward-driving force of history. The line "Time will surely move ahead" makes the poet's conception of time clear: forward movement is time's natural direction, while regression is an attempt to act against time. The image of the pachhmundiya, a creature whose head is turned backwards, represents forces attempting to reverse history's course. The movement will "wipe them out outright." Although the language is defiant, the poem does not simply call for counter-repression; it announces the historical impermanence of power founded upon fear and terror.

A limitation becomes visible here as well. History does not invariably move forward in a straight line; democratic achievements may be reversed. Yet within the political moment of the poem, faith in progress becomes a source of strategic energy. Poetry written for a movement often seeks not to predict events accurately but to build collective courage. From this perspective, the

future-tense phrase "will show" becomes an instrument of linguistic resistance.

3. The Call to Protest and Self-Examination of Opportunism in Leadership

The poet is not merely an unquestioning critic of the regime. He also scrutinises, with considerable acuity, opportunism, hypocrisy and failures of leadership within the movement itself. As a leader in a political party, Lal is intimately acquainted with the double character of political practitioners. In "Chalu Andolanme!" ("Come, Let Us Join the Movement!"; pp. 14–16), he calls upon the people to enter the struggle while subjecting the self-interest of leaders to severe examination:

"The sacrifice is yours; / they count it as their investment. / You are the one who gives your life; / they are the ones who swagger. / You must beg for alms; / here they have their motorcars. / It is you who may have taken the blows, / but they claim the manliness."

These lines express the bitter truth of revolution. Ordinary people, the poor and marginalised groups shed their blood in a movement, yet opportunistic leaders appropriate the dividends as a return on their "investment." People may die without receiving anything, while leaders who have done nothing display their supposed courage. By declaring that such figures possess "the gene of Raktabija" and have lost all shame, the poet makes clear how the overthrow of one autocrat may give rise to another ruler with precisely the same tendencies, like the proliferating demon Raktabija. The poem also reflects Lal's own eventual disillusionment, which later contributed to his departure from the established Nepali Congress and his search for an alternative in the TMLP.

In "Der Chhaik Anher Nahi!" ("There Is Delay, but Not Darkness"; pp. 17–18), the poet urges resistance to tyrannical power and counsels the people not to fear the "jackal wearing a tiger's skin"—a ruler at once cowardly and cruel. With the injunction "Our fists are like thunderbolts; / clench them tight and strike," he seeks to awaken confidence in the people's dormant strength.

At first hearing, the title sounds like an ordinary exhortation. The refrain "To raise cries of long life and downfall, / come, let us join the movement!" evokes the familiar sounds of political mobilisation. But stanza by stanza, the poem turns the slogan back upon itself and uncovers its internal irony. At the beginning are the ideals of bringing forward what is wanted, driving out what is unwanted, awakening the oppressed and challenging the oppressor. Immediately afterwards, however, the economy of sacrifice, martyrdom, heaven, honour, recognition and the prestige of leadership comes under interrogation.

Caste, factional bickering, the patronage of criminals, the demon Raktabija and the hunger for leadership are among the distortions within the movement that the poem regards as no less dangerous than the external enemy. In the final section, "You cannot live without movements; / their entire life resides in a movement" attacks the professional leadership of

permanent agitation. The people go in front, the leaders push from behind, and in the end "they will be leaders once again." Through this satire, Andolan avoids becoming self-congratulatory resistance poetry and gains the capacity for self-scrutiny.

The title reworks a familiar reassurance: justice may be delayed, but it has not been extinguished. The poem says, "Answer a blow with resistance." Does this constitute an endorsement of violent revenge? Seen in the context of the collection as a whole, the answer is not a simple yes. The poet's language is that of resistance, but he also condemns violence committed in the name of peace, the shooting of innocent people, and the trade conducted in sacrifice. It is more consistent to read "resistance" here politically, as a refusal of subordination and an assertion of rights.

Images such as "a thousand throats" and "fists like thunderbolts" create a sense of collective agency. Rather than the solitary heroic individual, what matters is the voice of a thousand people. At this point the democratic sensibility of the collection is unmistakable: the ethical basis of change lies in the people collectively, not in an individual saviour—even though the first poem summons B. P. Koirala as a symbolic redeemer. This internal tension lends the collection particular interest.

Practise renunciation, make sacrifices;

this is your duty.

For human life,

this indeed is the purpose and the essence.

4. A Philosophical Inquiry into Hollow Nationalism and Foreign Intervention

The definition of nationality has always been contested in the context of political movements. In "Hai, Hamar Rashtriyata!" ("Alas, Our Nationality!"; pp. 19–21), Vrishesh Chandra Lal—a poet rooted in Madhesh and an outspoken advocate of federalism and Madheshi identity—raises philosophical questions about Nepal's timid, fearful, artificial and narrow conception of nationhood.

"Gathering seven colours together, / this sun shines brightly; / when the many become one, / it gives off an extraordinary radiance. / But you, abandoning the one, / tremble as soon as you see two; / needlessly you puff out your face / and hide yourself in a cave. / Where do you drift away?"

The poem attacks the state-imposed nationalism of a single identity, associated here with Mahendra-era nationalism, which fears the linguistic, cultural and ethnic diversity of the country. A balanced sense of nationality is formed through unity in plurality, like the seven colours of a rainbow. Traditional nationalism in Nepal, however, retreats to a cave as soon as it encounters diversity and "rolls in the dirt." The poem also represents an intellectual sowing of the seeds of the Madhesh movement.

Similarly, "Road Map" (pp. 22–23) ridicules mediation by foreign powers, palace-centred peace processes conducted on paper, and solutions bearing the stamp of non-governmental organisations. The "road map" produced by outsiders has no place for the country's actual problems. The poet jokes that such a road map will not bring the country progress; instead, "the country itself will end up on the road / yes, now the country itself will end up on the road!" In other words, the nation will become destitute, like a beggar or someone without a home.

This four-part poem is among the collection's most intellectually mature works. The poet does not assume that nationality is a sacred value by definition; he asks how it actually behaves. Abandoning one's roots in search of origins, becoming enraged without reason, taking fright when a letter is inscribed, and clinging to a single identity instead of binding everyone together: these images depict an insecure, fear-producing and homogenising nationalism.

The lines establish a pluralist aesthetic of nationhood. The seven colours form a rainbow precisely because they remain distinct; unity is not the extinction of difference but the composition of coexistence. "Yet you, leaving the one, shudder when you see two" expresses the sickness of narrow nationalism, for which the very sight of plurality signifies division. Lal's poetry thus becomes an advocate of political pluralism. The lines acquire an additional resonance when read in light of later debates on federalism, but it is historically more appropriate to read the original poem in its setting around 2004.

The refrain "Everyone is flying into space, / but you keep rolling in the dirt" creates a sharp opposition between modernity and narrow-mindedness. The world is moving forward while nationalism rolls in the earth. Here the earth no longer signifies the sanctity of the motherland; it becomes an image of inertia and self-contraction. This transformation of the meaning of a single word is a noteworthy poetic achievement.

"Road Map" is a satirical reworking, in Maithili, of an English political-administrative expression. A village batāhā, or eccentric, buys a map and brings it home, announcing that roads are spread across it like a web. Gradually, the actual country, its people and its generations become subordinate to the map. The refrain "There will be no road in the country; / the country itself will end up on the road" is an outstanding example of paradox in the language of development planning. Instead of the instrument serving the country, the country is being forced inside the instrument.

The claim that "foreigners built enormous roads" and produced an even grander "map" raises, all at once, questions about external assistance, development projects, policy blueprints and sovereignty. The poem does not construct a simplistic anti-foreign nationalism. Its real target is government by maps, a system in which the complexities of local lives are subordinated to routes drawn on paper. The figure of the batāhā gives the satire the ease and immediacy of folk theatre.

5. The Proclamation of a Republic and Revolutionary Optimism

The collection reaches its ideological culmination in "Han, Han Lokkai Ganatantra Chahi!" ("Yes, Yes, the People Want a Republic!"; p. 24). The poem demands neither modest reform of government nor merely the replacement of ministers; it unequivocally calls for the overthrow of the entire feudal structure and the establishment of a republic:

"Yes, yes, this struggle is about power; / about bread, shelter and clothing; / people are no one's inherited property; / indeed, this is the struggle for people's sovereignty … / the people will beat the kettledrums and sound the great war-drum; / yes, yes, the people will burn Ravana's Lanka to ashes!"

Here "Ravana's Lanka" symbolises the feudal monarchy that ordinary people are preparing to burn down. In a democracy, a country is not anyone's inherited private property; the poem argues for sovereignty vested in the people.

Finally, "Kaal Mararait Chhaik!" ("Time Is Hovering!"; p. 25) and "Ijotdisi Sasarat!" ("It Will Move towards the Light!"; p. 26) echo the certainty of an oppressive ruler's downfall and the hope of a democratic dawn. The ruler is "trapped in his own net" and "has fallen into the pit of his own digging, raging there." No matter how loudly guns roar, they cannot prevent the colours of revolution:

"Guns thunder even today, / and guns will thunder tomorrow. / Who knows how many meek and innocent people / will suffer the blows of blunt axes? / Yet the colours of Holi will continue to rain down, / and its exuberance will spread still further. / These dark days of the present / will surely move towards the light!"

The political objective of the collection becomes especially clear in this poem: the struggle concerns power, but whose power? The answer is popular sovereignty. "People are no one's inherited property" is a foundational declaration of modern citizenship. The people are not recipients of charity or pity; they are bearers of rights. The line "They have endured the landlord's stick for long; / now, even with their own staff, the people will rise" becomes a metaphor for discarding dependence and discovering one's own strength.

In the second section, four propositions—"our own instruments," "entirely our own freedom," "we shall be no one's subjects," and "equality alone is the mantra of equality"—make republicanism more than opposition to monarchy. They turn it into a programme of popular ownership, liberty, emancipation from subjecthood and equality. The poem accordingly moves beyond the strictly institutional meaning of "republic" to embrace the idea of social democracy.

The final two poems complete the collection's emotional journey. In "Kaal Mararait Chhaik," history is almost like a hawk circling in the sky, while the people's flags fly everywhere. The exploiter has fallen into the pit he dug himself and has become entangled in his own net: these are images of political retribution resembling the workings of karma. The declaration "It will be

destroyed root and branch" represents the height of the movement's rhetorical fervour.

The final poem, however, articulates hope in a more complex manner. "Guns thunder even today / and guns will thunder tomorrow": the poet refuses to decorate the future with a false peace. Attacks upon the innocent may continue, yet the colours of Holi will keep falling, exuberance will spread and dark days "will move towards the light." This is an important conclusion. Hope is not the absence of violence, but the ceaseless renewal of life in its midst. The final voice is therefore more profoundly humane than a mere slogan.

Poem	Central theme and message	Political context
Aabah Na!	An appeal to B. P.; political regression depicted as a ghost	Royal coup (2002–05); attempts to restore royal supremacy
Shanti Chahi Muda Pharma Bamojim	Satire on the hollow peace of a militarised state	People trapped between military deployment and Maoist conflict
Durrar Baklel!	Hypocrisy of an autocratic ruler and repression of the people	Restrictions on freedom of expression and the king's authoritarian ambitions
Chalu Andolanme!	Call to protest and attack on opportunistic leaders	Popular martyrdom in revolution and the leadership's thirst for power
Hai, Hamar Rashtriyata!	Critique of narrow, fearful nationalism hostile to diversity	A state mentality treating Madheshi and other marginalised communities as unnational
Han, Han Lokkai Ganatantra Chahi!	Revolutionary proclamation of a republic and popular sovereignty	Mass movement to end monarchy and establish a democratic republic

Poetic Technique, Imagery and the Beauty of Language

The formal beauty of Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Andolan resides in its simplicity, incisiveness and the unmistakable earthy fragrance of Maithili. Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal" draws attention to its "figurative language, imagery, symbolism, representation of unvarnished reality, exhortation, indignation and remarkable formal inventiveness."

Traditional Maithili poetry was often burdened with Sanskrit-derived, tatsama vocabulary that could be difficult for ordinary readers to understand. Lal's poetic language, by contrast, is emphatically the language of the people.

Use of Vernacular and Indigenous Vocabulary: The poet employs Maithili's inherited and locally rooted vocabulary with exceptional vitality: pachhmuriya (backward-facing), pharma (a mould or template), baklel (fool), dhahlel, ghokchikay (drawing or shrinking in), ledha jait (deteriorating or rolling in dirt), suddah (burning completely), raiti (subject or tenant), bhasiyakay, tikba and thagba. These expressions give force to the people's language, strike directly at the reader's feelings and carry the discourse of revolution as far as the fields and threshing grounds.

Visual and Kinetic Imagery: The collection combines visual images with images of movement to striking effect. Political regression appears as a ghost with "feet turned backwards" and "blood on its teeth"; oppressive power as a "jackal wearing a tiger's skin"; and the destruction of tyranny as the spectacle of "Ravana's Lanka burnt utterly to ashes." These images make abstract political ideas stand before the mind's eye as pictures.

Rasa and Oblique Expression (Irony and Satire): Alongside the dominant heroic (vīra), furious (raudra) and repellent (bībhatsa) rasas, the collection employs ironic and satirical obliqueness. "Durrar Baklel!" and "Shanti Chahi Muda Pharma Bamojim" are outstanding instances of political satire. They expose the ruler's inhumanity through humour, inducing laughter that ultimately gives way to an acute awareness of suffering.

15. Language: Regional Maithili, Political Idiom and Oral Energy

The collection's language does not cultivate an ostentatious gravity through Sanskritisation. Vernacular expressions such as "hau," "ta," "aabah," "katta chhi," "nai," "kannekke," "baklel," "thenga" and "bataha" give the poems the immediacy of a speaking voice. This orality makes them effective on the stage, at public meetings, in civic dialogue and in recitation. Sentences are short, repetition is abundant and refrains return continually. The style increases the memorability of political verse.

The poet adopts the English administrative expression "road map" without translation, but by placing it in the world of Maithili folk understanding he reverses its meaning. Similarly, "zindabad–murdabad," the formulaic public language of political affirmation and denunciation, becomes an ironic echo in "Chalu Andolanme!" Lal's linguistic strategy may also be called postcolonial in this sense: he summons the vocabulary of government and development imported from outside before the tribunal of local linguistic judgment.

16. Form: Repetition, Address, Irony, Symbol and Visuality

16.1 Repetition and Refrain

Almost every major poem repeats a recognisable phrase or sonic motif: "Ee Andolan Dekha Det" ("This Movement Will Show Them"), "Chalu Andolanme" ("Come, Let Us Join the Movement"), "Der Chhaik Anher Nahi" ("There Is Delay, but Not Darkness"), "Hai, Hamar Rashtriyata" ("Alas, Our Nationality"), "Deshe Roadpar Ghuskatak" ("The Country Itself Will End Up on the Road"), and "Kaal Mararait Chhaik" ("Time Is Hovering"). Repetition here is not merely musical. The meaning changes with

every return. “Come, let us join the movement,” for instance, begins in enthusiasm, passes through doubt and finally acquires an ironic tone.

16.2 Dramatic Address

B. P. Koirala, an absent guide, the merchants of peace, nationality and the people: the poet directly addresses persons and even abstract ideas as though they were present. Through this technique, ideas become dialogue. Readers do not simply follow an argument; they seem to hear a voice addressing a public assembly.

16.3 Satire and Paradox

“Violence must be fitted into peace,” “The sacrifice is yours / they count it as their investment,” and “There will be no road in the country / the country itself will end up on the road” exemplify the paradoxes that constitute the collection’s finest poetic technique. Instead of explaining a contradiction, the poet causes its opposing elements to collide within the sentence. Readers encounter the incongruity for themselves.

16.4 Clusters of Symbols

Darkness and light, ghost and life, blood and flag, earth and space, road and map, baton and staff, gunfire and the colours of Holi: these dialectical pairs of symbols knit together the collection’s structure. In particular, the movement from darkness towards light establishes an internal architecture connecting the opening crisis with the final affirmation of hope.

17. The Collection’s Place within South Asian Poetry of Resistance

Political satire, vernacular speech, commitment to the people and direct attacks on power occur in many traditions of resistance poetry across the Indian subcontinent. In the wider context of Maithili and Hindi literature, one may be reminded of Nagarjun’s political satire in the language of ordinary people. In Hindi, Dhoomil’s suspicion of power, dismantling of democratic vocabulary and civic anger also offer grounds for comparison. Lal’s distinctive achievement, however, lies in the conjunction of Nepal’s democratic crisis, the symbolic presence of B. P. Koirala, the imagery of the Gorkhali state, the linguistic and cultural world of Janakpur, and the political experience of Nepalese Maithili speakers.

Such comparisons require care. The poems in Andolan are not primarily exercises in linguistic experimentation or profound introspective conflict; they are public poetry. Their central arena is not the private mind but the civic square. It would therefore be inappropriate to judge them solely by standards developed for intensely personal, formalist or mystical verse. Their achievement lies in communication through the people’s language, the force of their satire, historical urgency and moral clarity.

The Place of Andolan in Vrishesh Chandra Lal’s Oeuvre

Andolan must be considered in the context of Vrishesh Chandra Lal’s wider literary and political work. According to the biographical note at the end of the collection, the poet, born in 1955 (16 Chaitra 2011 in the Nepali calendar), is

a committed follower of B. P. Koirala and writes regularly on Nepalese politics in national dailies. In addition to this collection, his published works include his Maithili adaptation of B. P. Koirala's celebrated short novel Modiaain, the short-story collection Malho and the translation Sanghiyatak Sambandhme ("On Federalism").

Of particular importance is the outline of Lal's literary and political project that emerges when Andolan is considered alongside his Maithili translation of B. P. Koirala's Sumnima and the later poetry collection Dholak. Read together, these works reveal a coherent endeavour by the poet-translator: the sustained dissemination of B. P. Koirala's democratic-socialist ideas in Maithili through translation, and direct intervention in contemporary Nepalese political crises through original poetry, in Andolan and Dholak. Among these connected works, Andolan is the most immediate and slogan-driven. Whereas Dholak gives broader scope to social justice, Dalit consciousness and questions concerning women, Andolan responds directly, and almost exclusively, to an immediate political emergency—the dissolution of parliament.

Because the stated publication date of Andolan is Vikram Samvat 2061, the view that places its publication close to 2021–22 CE is inconsistent with the chronology. Nevertheless, reading Sumnima, Dholak and Andolan together in terms of ideological and literary relations retains considerable critical value.

The Historical Place of the Collection in Nepalese Maithili Literature

Nepalese Maithili literature has a substantial tradition extending from Vidyapati's poetry of love and devotion to modern social realism. Writers such as Rambharos Kapari "Bhramar," Rajendra Vimal and Dhirendra Premarshi have enriched this tradition. Yet although a current of political poetry certainly existed in Maithili, a whole collection devoted specifically to contemporary politics, the cruelty of power, state repression and the cries of popular protest was relatively rare.

Dr Vimal's assertion is that "for the first time in Nepalese Maithili literature a poetry collection has appeared in which every poem is inspired by contemporary politics." Vrishesh Chandra Lal's endeavour takes Maithili poetry, on the one hand, beyond the pleasures of the private chamber and idealistic sermonising into the revolutionary front line of the street. On the other, it gives democratic activists an intellectual weapon. Three streams converge in Andolan: B. P. Koirala's socialism, the marginalised consciousness of Madhesh and the universal values of democracy.

18. Principal Achievements of the Poetry Collection

Maintaining a critical perspective on both the government and the movement, thereby avoiding the danger that political poetry might become party propaganda.

Transforming the complex questions of contemporary history into memorable, visual images expressed through the people's language.

Testing nationality against the standards of plurality, civic courage and equality.

Exposing the self-interested politics concealed within apparently positive terms such as peace, development, sacrifice and leadership.

Presenting the people not as objects of pity but as political agents and the source of popular sovereignty.

Fashioning the final hope not as a simplified proclamation of victory but as the persistence of life amid ongoing violence.

19. Limitations and Critical Questions

Serious literary evaluation is not simply praise. The strengths of Andolan are evident, but so are certain limitations. First, many poems depend heavily upon allusions specific to the politics of their time. Future readers unfamiliar with B. P. Koirala, political regression, the ethos of Gorkhali state power and the particular context of movement leadership may miss the full force of some of the satire. Historical annotations would therefore be valuable in a critical edition.

Second, refrain-like slogans are often energetic, yet in some passages repetition diminishes poetic density. Vehemence can occasionally overpower subtlety. Third, the collection centres on a national crisis of political power. Other dimensions—the particular experiences of women and workers, Dalit questions, the fine grain of class relations, and rural political economy—may be suggested, but they do not develop into independent poetic explorations.

Fourth, the conviction that history "moves forward" is inspiring, but gives comparatively little space to the crooked course of political history, the failure of movements, divisions among the people and the complexities of democratic institutions. Even so, "Chalu Andolanme!" and "Hai, Hamar Rashtriyata!" introduce a necessary element of self-doubt into this linear account. These poems prevent the collection from becoming a one-directional manifesto.

Conclusion and Contemporary Relevance

Taken as a whole, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Maithili poetry collection Andolan is not merely an assortment of verses or a book intended for literary pleasure. It is a living, passionate and authentic manifesto of a period of historic political transition in Nepal. The poems were born when the dark clouds of autocracy hovered over the country, when the bayonet of the gun was being described as "peace," and when citizens were being stripped of their rights. Bringing together long political experience, social sensitivity and the popular force of the Maithili language, Lal has fashioned the poetic gold of resistance.

The book's philosophical depth lies in the fact that it does not oppose only the autocracy of the monarch of its day. It attacks, with equal severity, hypocritical leaders who deceive the people in the name of movements, hollow nationalists who fear diversity, and forms of neo-colonial foreign

intervention exemplified by the "road map." Andolan demonstrates how, when political commitment genuinely converges with literary sensibility, literature ceases to be merely entertainment and becomes a potent instrument of social transformation. In the study of democratic consciousness, the establishment of a republic, debates on federalism and contemporary political discourse, the volume will remain an invaluable resource and point of reference in Maithili letters. It testifies to literature's ability to carry a torch and show the way whenever politics loses its direction.

20. Overall Evaluation

It is appropriate to call Andolan an important popular-democratic document of political poetry in Nepalese Maithili, but the word "document" alone is insufficient. The document becomes literature when the "ghost" becomes a symbol of political regression, when the "merchants of peace" expose the hypocrisy of policy language, when "sacrifice" becomes the leader's "investment," when a "road map" devours a country, when "nationality" rolls in the dirt during the space age, and when history shifts towards light even amidst the sound of gunfire.

The poet's most significant achievement is his refusal to treat democracy merely as a question of parliament or opposition to monarchy. For him, democracy is a constellation of language, thought, plurality, self-respect, popular rights, accountability in leadership and the people's ownership of power. "People are no one's inherited property" is the most concise formulation of this philosophy.

From a literary standpoint, the collection's most effective poems include "Shanti Chahi Muda Pharma Bamojim," "Durr Baklel!," "Chalu Andolanme!," "Hai, Hamar Rashtriyata!" and "Road Map," since they transform immediate political circumstances into enduring irony. "Aabah Na!" and "Ee Andolan Dekha Det" provide historical energy, while "Ijotdisi Sasarat!" gives the collection an open ending founded upon humane hope.

Ultimately, the value of Andolan lies in its refusal merely to ask readers to take the side of a movement. Instead it asks: For whom is the movement? For whom is peace? Who makes the sacrifices, and who takes the rewards? Is the nation a single colour, or the harmonious radiance of seven? Does development take shape within the country, or is the country forced into a paper "road map"? Do the people bring power into being, or does power regard the people as its tenants and subjects? These questions enable a small book to outgrow its moment and become a lasting poetic text of democratic judgment.

"People are no one's inherited property": in this single line resides the democratic soul of Andolan.

The collection was written at a particular historical moment, but its finest poems cross the boundaries of that moment and become enduring inquiries into power and citizenship. Here lies the literary triumph of Andolan.

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2. Dholak

Source book: Dholak (Maithili poetry collection)
Author: Vrishesh Chandra Lal
Publisher: Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham

1. Introduction and Theoretical Background

In the contemporary landscape of Maithili literature, particularly in the context of Nepalese Mithila, poetry is no longer merely a vehicle for aesthetic appreciation or the spontaneous expression of emotion. It has become a powerful instrument of revolution, social justice, the anguish of marginalised communities and democratic consciousness. At the forefront of this transformation in thought and practice stands the distinguished politician, thinker and writer Vrishesh Chandra Lal. His recently published collection of Maithili poems, Dholak (Vikram Samvat 2078), raises the aesthetic possibilities of literature to new heights while offering an exceptionally authentic and affecting record of society's troubled realities, political hypocrisy, the exploitation of marginalised classes and the human will to live.

The interdependent relationship between literature and society is borne out by Lal's work in its entirety. Dholak is not simply an assemblage of poems; it is a document of an age in which the heat of revolution, the anguish of disillusionment and a resolve to rebuild flow together.

Overview

Dholak is a poetry collection that moves, seemingly in a single breath, through child psychology, folk songs, the public life of Janakpur and Madhesh, political resistance, labour, poverty, questions of gender, inner conflict, an awareness of death, festivity and irony. Its structure is meaningful in itself: Bal-Khand (the children's section), Tal-Khand (the section of rhythm) and Nal-Khand (the section of the drum's deeper resonance). According to the contents, the first section has twenty compositions, the second fourteen and the third sixty-two: ninety-six poems or songs in all. The sequence suggests the poet's journey from the spontaneous sounds of

childhood to rhythmic communal song, and thence to the social pulse—the nal—of collective life.

The collection's most distinctive quality is its use of sound. Sounds such as "furr-furr," "dhum-dhum," "dhak-dhak," "chakke-chakdum," "bhuku-bhuku" and "jogira" are not mere embellishments; they carry meaning. Sound connects the body, celebration, fear, resistance, children's games and folk memory. The title Dholak likewise occupies the centre of this politics of sound: the drum is brought into use during communal activities, only to be hung up once more in a dark corner when its work is done. In this image one may read the utilitarian social fate of artists, labourers, Dalits and other deprived people, political workers and ordinary citizens alike.

The poetic quality of the ninety-six compositions is not uniform. Some leave a lasting impression through imagery, rhythm and satire; elsewhere the poet states his ideas in declarative lines before those ideas can fully become poetry. Yet this unevenness does not diminish the collection's historical importance. Rather, it illuminates the nature of the poet's public personality and his writing as a citizen. The essential value of Dholak lies in its readiness for dialogue with the people, the energy of its spoken language, folk rhythms, political fearlessness and close observation of social life.

Principal Findings

Structure	Bal: 20 + Tal: 14 + Nal: 62 = 96 compositions; a gradual expansion from the sounds of childhood to social and political consciousness.
Principal poetic strengths	Folk rhythms, repetition, onomatopoeic vocabulary, lyricism and public orality.
Major themes	Childhood, nature, celebration, love, poverty, labour, Madhesh/Janakpur, opposition to power, moral questions and existential awareness.
Distinctive symbol	The dholak as a metaphor for people, art and labour used by society, then hung up again in a corner after being played.
Limitations	Excessive declarative statements, repetition, uneven metrical control, and at times a reduction of imaginative freedom through overly direct illustrations.
Overall assessment	An important social document of modern, folk-oriented Maithili poetry, particularly notable within Nepal's Maithili-speaking public sphere.

2. The Poet's Personality, Political Background and Their Relationship to His Work

To comprehend the depth of any enduring literary work, one must also understand its creator's philosophy of life and experience of struggle. Vrishesh Chandra Lal, whose name at the sixth-day naming ceremony was Vishweshwar, is not merely an emotional or imaginative poet. He is a leading participant, thinker and popular leader in Nepal's democratic movement and the struggle for Madhesh rights. He was born on 29 March 1955 in Suga-Bhawanipatti, Mahottari district, to the late Udit Narayan Lal and Bhuvaneshwari Devi. His life has been arduous, marked by an unbroken struggle for democracy in Nepal, the end of the Panchayat system and equality among citizens. In the course of this struggle he was arrested seventeen times and spent approximately eight years in prison. A committed political follower of Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala, he has held such positions as national vice-president of the Tarai Madhesh Loktantrik Party (TMLP), mayor of Janakpurdham and member of the National Assembly of Nepal's federal parliament (2017–19).

His contribution to literature is by no means confined to Dholak. His earlier poetry collection Andolan helped awaken the people during the period of political regression. He also enriched Maithili letters considerably by adapting B. P. Koirala's celebrated short novels Sumnima and Modiaain into Maithili. For his translation of Sumnima he received the Nepal Vidyapati Maithili Translation Award, recognition of his command of language and lucid Maithili expression. His involvement in the Maithili movement and events such as Vidyapati Remembrance Day demonstrates that he regards language not simply as a means of communication but as an instrument of regional identity and self-respect. In Vikram Samvat 2074 the Mithila Natya Kala Parishad (MINAP) bestowed on him the well-known satirical title of Mahamurkh, a sign of his standing in Mithila's intellectual and social life. His literary commitment extends further: he established an endowment in his parents' names and initiated a practice of honouring Maithili writers through awards.

The poet's long political struggle, revolutionary experience, suffering in prison and concern for ordinary people do not enter his poetry as hollow party slogans or dry pronouncements. Instead they find voice as the bloodstained reality, tears, sweat and stubborn vitality of oppressed Dalit people at the lowest rung of society. The darkness of prison, the clamour of people's movements, the pain of neglected social groups and the grotesque spectacle of those at the summit of power all constitute the raw materials of Lal's poetic world. This uncommon conjunction of politics and literature gives his writing a distinctive edge: he does not escape reality but stands in the midst of struggle and sounds the call for reconstruction. A senior writer such as Dr Shefalika Verma likewise acknowledges that, despite his political commitments and busy life, the time Lal finds for literature continually enriches the treasury of the Maithili language.

The Book, the Poet and the Literary Context

It would be a mistake to regard Lal's literary identity merely as an appendix to his political career. Available biographical accounts place his birth in Suga-Bhawanipatti, Mahottari district; postgraduate study in economics, training in labour studies, public and political life, the writing of stories and poems, and translation all make his experience many-layered. His Maithili adaptations of B. P. Koirala's Modiaain and Sumnima establish his identity as a translator; the Nepal Vidyapati Maithili Translation Award of Vikram Samvat 2077 provides institutional recognition of that work. Against this background, a reading of Dholak shows that the poet does not simply turn speeches delivered from political platforms into verse. He brings the home, children, ponds, birds, love, the city, poverty, religious symbols, hunger, violence resembling war, celebrations and personal loneliness into a single poetic field.

Jayakant Mishra and Devkant Jha, both historians of modern Maithili literature, identify the widening presence of social realism, experimentation, lyricism, satire and civic consciousness as important tendencies in modern poetry. Dholak may be seen as a Nepalese-Madheshi manifestation of this longer tradition. On one side stand the cultural memory of Vidyapati's song tradition and folk sound; on the other, modern democratic discontent, urban crises, deprivation of labour and global anxieties.

The critical essays by Rajendra Vimal and Parmeshwar Kapari at the beginning of the book draw attention to its social concerns, environmental awareness, political rights, class inequality, folk rhythm and human compassion.

The Prefaces: Background to the Poet and His Work

Vrishesh Chandra Lal is not only a poet but an active politician. He has served as mayor of Janakpurdham and as a respected member of the first National Assembly of Nepal's federal democratic republic. This biographical background is crucial to understanding Dholak. According to Dr Rajendra "Vimal" in his preface, one of the essential features of the collection is that it was not written by a politician during the leisure afforded by imprisonment. It was composed by a soldier with a poet's heart, fighting on the battlefield of Nepal's continuing struggle to end discrimination. In the preface writer's image, it is as though Lord Krishna were standing in the midst of Kurukshetra, expounding the Gita. This proposition itself shapes the register in which the collection is read.

According to the second preface writer, Parmeshwar Kapari, Lal is an accomplished politician familiar with the turmoil and manoeuvring of contemporary politics, yet apart from all this he is also an experienced poet whose perceptions rest on the authenticity of minute observation, and who examines life and the world attentively. This dual identity—poet and politician—is especially evident throughout the collection. What appears here is not merely a selection of beautiful words, but a front of direct intervention in social and political life.

The Reciprocal Relationship between the Work and Its Author

Reading the collection, we must not forget that its author is not merely a man of letters. He is also a politician who has participated in the struggles of the Maithili-speaking region through municipal leadership, National Assembly membership and periods of agitation. The author of Dholak has therefore experienced the very scenes that he evokes. This makes Dr Rajendra Vimal's comparison in the preface particularly apt: as though Krishna were standing in the midst of Kurukshetra delivering the Gita, so this poet stands amid the field of struggle and creates poetry.

3. The Book's External and Internal Organisation (Metadata and Structural Profile)

An academic assessment of a book begins with its basic structure and publication details, which establish the first bridge between the work and its readers. The following tables present factual particulars concerning the publication and arrangement of Dholak.

Bibliographical component	Details
Book title	Dholak (collection of Maithili poetry)
Author	Vrishesh Chandra Lal
Publisher	Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham-2, Kishorinagar, Nepal
Printer	Union Offset Press, Janakpurdham
Publication date / edition	First edition: Magh 2078 Vikram Samvat (January 2022)
Print run	1,000 copies
Price	200 taka / rupees
Cover illustration	Manoj Kumar Yadav
Dedication	To parents and revered teachers
Prefaces	1. Dr Rajendra Vimal ("Evergreen Rhythms Played on Poet Lal's Dholak") 2. Parmeshwar Kapari ("Where Should I Begin?")
Structural divisions	Three sections: 1. Bal-Khand (20 compositions) 2. Tal-Khand (15 songs) 3. Nal-Khand (62 poems)
Author	**Vrishesh Chandra Lal**
Genre	Maithili poetry collection (also printed in the Tirhuta script)
Publisher	Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham-2, Kishorinagar
Edition	First edition, Magh 2078 Vikram

Bibliographical component	Details
	Samvat
Cover artwork	Manoj Kumar Yadav
Price	200 taka
Pages	160
Structure	Three sections: Bal-Khand, Tal-Khand and Nal-Khand (a total of 62 poems)

At the beginning of the book the poet offers statements under the headings "Shubhkamana" (Good Wishes) and "Vinay" (Supplication), explaining that this poetry collection consists of whatever "strikes against the nal as it happens to come." Opening with "Tasmai Shri Gurave Namah" ("Salutations to that revered teacher"), the volume also preserves its cultural and spiritual roots.

4. The Philosophical Basis of Dholak's Threefold Structure

The entire creative world of Dholak is divided into three carefully organised sections: Bal-Khand, Tal-Khand and Nal-Khand. The three divisions symbolise a three-dimensional process of development in human life and society, constructed around the metaphor of a musical instrument, the dholak. This arrangement is not a random compilation; a serious philosophical and psychological design underlies it.

The first division, Bal-Khand, symbolises infancy, innocence and primary socialisation. Through child psychology, the poet depicts ethical instruction, social contradictions and folk games. The second, Tal-Khand, represents the cultural, musical and emotional youth of society. Within it resound the rhythms of Mithila's customary auspicious ceremonies, erotic and romantic feeling, love, separation and the satire of a new age. The third and final division, Nal-Khand, gives voice to mature social struggle, revolution, philosophical gravity and a cry of opposition to the prevailing order. Nal here denotes the drum's deeper, left-hand side, from which its resonant bass sound emerges: an apt designation for this section's seriousness and revolutionary consciousness.

"Bal–Tal–Nal": The Poetics of the Three Names

At first glance, the names of these three sections may seem playful, but they constitute one of the book's strongest editorial and poetic decisions. Bal signifies the child, beginnings, tenderness and spontaneous sound; tal signifies rhythm, collective singing, bodily movement and celebration; nal signifies the organic connection sustaining life, its inner nerves and arteries and its bond with its source. Thus the book travels from the childish wonder of "Furr-Furr Suga" to the collective utterance of "Jagaran Git," and then to such works as "Manukhbhamara," "Samay," "Dholak!," "Khoji Rahal Chhi...," "Chuppi," "Khun Ta Khun Chhaik!," "Nari," "Musaharke Ham Bachcha Chhi!," "Pet" and "He Bhagwan!"

The sequence is also developmental. In Bal-Khand, the objects remain external—birds, fruit, the moon, kites, telephones, curds and books, lamps and ponds. In Tal-Khand, the outer world becomes a collective voice—good wishes, awakening, Holi, love, dance and anklets. In Nal-Khand, the poet directly confronts tensions between inner and outer life—poverty, the city, democracy, blood, hunger, power, loneliness, women, religion, war and ethical questions. Nal thus becomes a link between individual existence and the social body.

The Three-Part Structure

5. Bal-Khand: Child Psychology, Folk Play and the Seeds of a New Consciousness

Writing literature for children is regarded as a demanding literary undertaking in any language. An adult, experienced writer must set aside the display of learning and scholarship and enter fully into childlike tenderness, rhymed musicality and the playful disposition of the young mind. Vrishesh Chandra Lal proves notably successful in this respect. Bal-Khand contains twenty children's poems and songs. Its distinctive feature is the planting of serious social and cultural messages, political satire and the seeds of ethical understanding within a child's world. These poems are written not simply to entertain but also to introduce future generations to social reality.

5.1 Political Satire and a New Panchatantra

Children's poems have long employed images from the world of birds, animals and nature. Lal likewise creates a new Panchatantra through the wagtail, parrot, crow, mouse and other creatures, but gives these figures a pronounced modern political and social consciousness. In “Dum-Dum Baua,” the crow serves to warn a child against cunning and opportunistic people, particularly corrupt leaders or self-interested friends. The poet wants the young mind to understand that society is full of people who will bow before others to achieve their own purposes, only to fly away as soon as their task is accomplished. The crow's character exposes those opportunists who creep close and, on finding an opening, snatch what they want and flee. Dr Rajendra Vimal makes clear in his preface how serious a satire upon contemporary political actors in Nepal these lines constitute. Under the covering of a children's song, this vivid depiction of opportunism discloses a mature political truth.

Similarly, the poem “Musari Badd Peraia” uses the figure of a mouse to attack feudal exploitation and corruption—the social class that appropriates other people's grain without undertaking labour of its own. Here the mouse represents parasitic groups that quietly hollow out society's resources from within, enter other people's homes uninvited and consume their fill. While instilling the values of hard work and honesty in the child's imagination, the poem also cultivates a distaste for exploitative conduct.

The poem “Farr-Farr Suga” affirms the importance of freedom by depicting the plight of a caged parrot. Forced to repeat “Ram-Ram,” the bird's inner life

has been darkened by captivity. The poem also echoes the poet's own experience of political imprisonment. Its message to children is that freedom requires struggle: until the bond or cage is cut, no amount of lowering one's head will bring release. These lines teach the value of sovereignty and liberty —freedom is won not through supplication but through resistance.

5.2 Women's Questions and the Revolution of Girls' Education

The poet makes an affecting attack upon the gender inequality present in Maithil society and South Asian society more broadly. "Ge Daiya Hamro Dahi Kitab" is a revolutionary appeal for girls' education. The poem directly confronts the double standard of patriarchal society, in which sons are sent to school while daughters are obliged to cut grass. When the girl sees her brothers going to school, her own thirst for knowledge awakens and she asks her mother for books.

The poet further calls for the breaking of the social illusion by which a son is nurtured as the saviour of the family line while a daughter is neglected. In his view such discrimination is progressively reducing society to a skeleton, for no society or nation can advance while keeping half its members uneducated. This realistic and heartbreaking representation of girls' empowerment establishes the poet as a progressive social reformer and offers an excellent example of gender sensitivity in children's literature.

5.3 Child Psychology and the Contradictions of the Modern Family

"Phone Karaia Nanaji" offers a psychological portrayal of the loneliness experienced by contemporary children as a result of urbanisation, capitalist development and the rise of the nuclear family. In the working lives of parents and the mechanised routines of children, the love, stories and songs of grandparents have become scarce; the poet expresses this absence in an accessible child's idiom. Both mother and father hurry to their offices, while the child has little more than food packed in a lunchbox. Into this emotional emptiness comes a telephone call from the maternal grandfather, whom the child asks to sing a song. The poem draws attention to a tragedy of modern life: material comforts are available, but the warmth of the extended family and the oral tradition are disappearing.

In "Guddi Urae Akashme," the poet uses a kite to portray life's ascent and the competition inherent in it: the kite climbs when its string is pulled, and the children compete to cut one another's kite strings. This children's game becomes a fine metaphor for the struggle of life.

5.4 Cultural Inheritance and the Representation of Nature

Other poems in Bal-Khand contain vivid depictions of Mithila's folk festivals, seasonal changes and natural beauty. They help connect younger generations with their soil, food and customs. "Chaurchan Chaurchan Ugal Chan" celebrates the Chaurchan festival of moon-viewing in the month of Bhadra. The child longs for puris, curds, pirukia, milk-based sweets, tarua, tilkor leaves and coconuts. "Majjar" depicts the fragrance of mango blossoms

and the humming of bees, along with the anticipation of making amot (dried mango pulp) and amarasa (mango juice).

"Hori Aelai Hurrrr!" describes the colour and exuberance of Phagun: malpua, bari and tarua are being fried, drums and tasha are sounding, and water squirters are spraying colour. Poems such as "Chakaike Chakdhum" and "Ta Ta Thaiya Karu Baua" capture a child's innocent delight while playing in the laps of grandparents. Songs such as "Pokharik Kat," "Son Chiriya" and "Aa Aa Re Khanjan Chiriya" draw the child's imagination towards nature and establish an affinity with birds and animals.

Bal-Khand: Sound, Image and Child Psychology

It may seem easy to write children's verse, but merely shortening the language does not make a successful poem for children. Such poetry requires wonder, repetition, play, sound, images and a memorable movement. In many instances Dholak's Bal-Khand meets these requirements. The very titles —"Furr-Furr Suga," "Guddi Urae Akashme," "Dhum-Dhum Kaua," "Furr-Furr Bagara," "Phone Karaia Nanaji," "Ta Ta Thaiya Kar Kaua," "Hori Aelai Hurrrr!," "Chakke Chakdum," "Son Chiriya," "Chamak-Chamak Diyabati" and "Musari Bahu Peraia"—already generate sound and movement.

In the poems of Bal-Khand, imitative sound is the first gateway to meaning. A child does not initially encounter the crow or parrot through biological description, but experiences the world through sounds such as "furr," "dhum," "chak" and "ta-ta thaiya." The poet intuitively grasps this psychological truth. Repetition gives the lines their music while giving the language a circularity consonant with a child's patterns of memory.

Illustrations are generally helpful in this section. Direct images of birds, kites, lamps, fruits and children allow young readers immediate entry into the text. Yet there is also a literary limitation: when an image is too explicit, it can reduce the imaginative freedom of the visual world created by the poem itself. A future edition employing Mithila painting or a consistent style of original line drawing could give the collection a more distinctive visual identity.

Another important feature of Bal-Khand is familial intimacy. In "Phone Karaia Nanaji," "Ge Daiya Hamro Dahi Kitab" and "Son Chiriya," family relationships and domestic forms of address lend the poems the warmth of everyday speech. This helps prevent children's literature from turning into mere moral instruction, even though the intended message is explicit in several poems.

Bal-Khand (Twenty Poems)

At first sight, the poems in Bal-Khand appear to be straightforward children's literature—simple rhyming verses on birds, thieves and other creatures, festivals, games and family affection, such as "Farr-Farr Suga," "Ta Ta Yaiya Kar Baua" and "Aa Aa Re Khanjan Chiriya." But closer examination reveals the poet's social consciousness surfacing here as well. "Farr-Farr Suga" describes the suffering of a chilli-eating parrot shut in a cage, and closes with lines to the effect that "the bond will not be broken unless it is cut, however

much the head and shoulders may be lowered." This brings the consciousness of freedom into a child's song. For Lal, then, children's literature is not only entertainment but also a means of cultivating values.

An engaging instance of verbal play occurs in the poem "Karona." On reading the title, one naturally recalls the worldwide coronavirus pandemic; in fact, the poem is a simple children's verse about the karonda fruit found in Mithila. Children pick the fruit, gather it to make pickle, and flee after driving away a bear with sharp, clattering sounds. This verbal coincidence also displays the poet's linguistic playfulness.

6. Tal-Khand: Traditional Auspiciousness, Love, Separation and the Contradictions of Modernity

The second section of Dholak is Tal-Khand, containing fifteen songs. This group of compositions draws on the rhythms of Mithila's classical and folk music—its melodic patterns, beats and measures. It gives musical form to matters ranging from ancient traditions to modern contradictions. The poet here demonstrates his deep understanding of folk culture and sensitivity to music.

6.1 A New Sama Veda and Auspicious Song

In his preface, the senior critic Parmeshwar Kapari calls "Shubhe Ho Shubhe!" a "new folk Sama Veda song." The poet transforms the conventional mantra "Shubhe He Shubhe," used in Mithila's customary chumaon ritual of blessing and often reduced to formula, into an invocation for the social and national well-being of a new age. The new mantra prays not merely for an individual's good fortune but for the honour, health, service, prosperity and virtues of the whole community. It asks that strength dwell in the courtyard, happiness find a place in the home, every household have its supply of grain, and children be as precious as gold. The folk song is thus no longer simply a religious incantation; it becomes a collective, secular prayer for a prosperous, healthy and peaceful society.

6.2 Cultural Pride and the Voice of Awakening

"Siyajik Chhanh Ai Biah, Janakpurme" presents a living picture of the traditional celebration of Sita's marriage. The poet evokes the cultural significance of that marriage in Mithila's folk voice through the breaking of the bow by the young prince of Ayodhya, the exchange of wedding garlands, the dancing peacocks of Mithila, decorations in the bridal chamber and paintings on bamboo, and the ceremonial welcome of Rama and Lakshmana. The song celebrates Mithila's cultural identity and historical pride.

In "Jagaran Git" ("Song of Awakening"), by contrast, the poet speaks as a soldier of the democratic movement, calling upon the people to awaken. A wind of revolution is blowing, darkness is receding, and the time has come to advance like a flaming torch. Attacking the preservation of the status quo, he asks how long people will sleep after surrendering their rights and flee in fear when the hour of resistance arrives. This call to clench one's fists and fight for justice shakes the dormant consciousness of society.

6.3 The Vidyapati Tradition: Erotic Love and the Pain of Separation

In his songs, Lal gives new life, through fresh language and imagery, to the rich Maithili tradition of erotic love and separation associated with the great poet Vidyapati. Songs such as “Gorki Najari Mor,” “Dhak Dhak Karay Karej Mor,” “Nai Aau Ena Monme,” “Pritak Gitme” and “Jhunuk Jhun Jhunjhun Payal Baje” express sensuous affection, physical beauty and the deep ache of separation.

“Gorki Najari Mor” offers an intoxicating portrait of the heroine's beauty: one glance from her steals the lover's heart. The moon seems to smile in the flush of her cheeks, the rose in her hair appears bashful, and the tinkling of her anklets quickens the heartbeat. These images recall Vidyapati's aesthetic sensibility.

Nature is also personified strikingly in the depiction of separation. In “Dhak Dhak Karay Karej Mor,” a monsoon sky crowded with clouds, a moon that appears and disappears, and a cuckoo calling “ku-ku” intensify the longing of a woman separated from her beloved. In “Jhunuk Jhun Jhunjhun Payal Baje,” a night of separation seems as long as an age, while moments spent with the beloved are painfully brief. These songs demonstrate that, amid the clamour of politics, an innocent and tender emotional world remains alive within the poet.

6.4 The Grotesqueries of Modernity and Pop Satire

The most distinctive composition in this section is “Katasan Karu Shuru.” According to Parmeshwar Kapari, this was Maithili's first “pop song,” composed by the poet in 1986 and later made highly popular through the first Maithili telefilm, Dahej. Written to the rhythm of Western disco dance, it delivers sharp and unsparing satire upon the political and social corruption of both its original period and the present. It fully exposes a decline in social values and a mentality centred on money.

The poet depicts the directionlessness of the modern generation: it is as though the written alphabet means no more than black marks to a buffalo, yet the young know the films of Hema Malini and Dharmendra. Education seems worthless, since those who occupy positions of authority take bribes, enjoy themselves and ride in cars, while intelligent people remain helpless. The poet renders with precision a social reality in which, without money, neither father nor mother seems to matter. The song's ironic exhortation to take up smuggling is, in reality, a resounding slap in the face of a corrupt system.

Tal-Khand: Song, Celebration and the Collective Body

Tal-Khand forms the collection's middle territory. Here poetry asks less to be read in silence than to be sung, repeated, spoken from a stage or experienced collectively. Compositions including “Shubhkamana Git,” “Jagaran Git,” “Han Re Sugana,” “Dhak-Dhak Karay Karej Mor,” “Horik Git,” “Pritak Gitme,” “Bhuku-Bhuku Kun Kunukun Payal Baje,” “Ekta Sugan

Git," "Ash Banchite Rahat" and "Gorki Najari Mor" plainly exhibit refrains, direct address, rhythmic repetition and patterns of folk singing.

In "Shubhkamana Git," the repetition of good fortune, life, health, respect and related wishes gives the song a ritual quality. "Jagaran Git" turns political and social consciousness into the rhythms of song. In "Horik Git," colour, the body, laughter, love and community move together. The value of these compositions is not confined to the written page. Their full life may unfold on stages, in processions, at festivals or in gatherings. Accordingly, it is not enough to treat Dholak solely as a printed volume of poetry: it is also a document of orally performed verse.

The language of Tal-Khand generally rests upon short lines, pauses shaped by sound and recurring phrases. Classical metrical discipline is not rigid in every composition, but an audible beat is continually at work. The distinction matters: irregularity in written metre does not necessarily imply an absence of rhythm. Many of these poems follow the breath of folk performance rather than the grammatical length of a line.

Tal-Khand (Fifteen Poems)

The compositions in Tal-Khand are songs and short lyrics dealing with love, separation, union, festivals and customary rites. In a song such as "Siyajik Chhanh Ai Biah, Janakpurme," the poet centres Janakpurdham's cultural identity on the wedding of Sita and Rama, rooting a work in his own language in the land with which it is associated. "Han Re Sugaba" and "Dhak-Dhak Karay Karej Mor" exhibit both the rhythmic structure and the figurative ornamentation of folk song. The concluding piece, "Kattasan Shuru," is a satire on corruption which, according to both learned preface writers, was also used in the first Maithili telefilm, Dahejme Ael Chhi.

7. Nal-Khand: Social Reality, Revolution and Philosophical Debate

The collection's third and most serious division is Nal-Khand, comprising sixty-two poems. Nal refers here to the deeper-sounding side of the dholak. In these works the poet stands on the naked, uneven ground of life, approached through rational inquiry, and seeks human and historical values. This division offers the fullest expression of his political experience, philosophical reflection and sociological vision.

7.1 The Metaphor of the Dholak: The Anguish of Marginalised Groups and the Reality of Exploitation

The title poem, "Dholak!," is an intensely moving and living symbol of the neglected, exploited and proletarian classes. The poet perceives a remarkable parallel between the physical fate of the drum and the social fate of marginalised people. He describes the instrument being left hanging in a corner of the thatched dwelling. Yet whenever there is a celebration, a devotional gathering, or an occasion of birth or death, it is taken down and put to use.

The line in which the drum is "held beneath the thigh and beaten" is a precise metaphor for the extreme physical and psychological exploitation of working people. The elite or holders of political power use the proletariat—labourers, Dalits and the oppressed—only for their own "celebrations": elections, development projects and political movements. When the work is finished, the people so used are returned to the "dark corner" of society and left to an anonymous existence, like the drum hung up again under a torn, musty covering. This is an outstanding example of Marxist and subaltern discourse, combining estrangement with rebellion.

The Symbolic Meaning of the Title "Dholak"

The title poem "Dholak!" (p. 54) is the intellectual centre of the book. Its central movement is unmistakable: the drum plays for celebrations, devotional songs, births and deaths, practice and customary rites alike; but once it has been used, it is hung up again on the same peg, in the same corner, in darkness.

Dholak! It hangs there, suspended,

Tied to a peg driven into the corner of the thatch!

...

They hang it up again in the dark!!

In this poem the dholak becomes an image of proletarian and working-class existence: it sounds endlessly for the pleasure of others, never for its own satisfaction. In the piece entitled "Vinay," the poet himself connects the act of writing to the same metaphor:

Within the dholak's rolling sound, these and other words too are struck into rhythm, even if they beat out of time.

The "opinions" and "mockery" of the unheeding are woven together, without their knowing it!!

It becomes evident that the title Dholak points not merely to a rural musical instrument but also represents the poet's own creative labour: an instrument that gives rhythm to the opinions and mockery of those who do not listen, even when the blows produce sounds outside the proper beat. Internal evidence from the collection's structure supports this interpretation. The division titles Tal-Khand and Nal-Khand extend the dholak into a governing structural metaphor: tal denotes beat and musical rhythm, while nal evokes an inner pulse and the beating of the arteries.

7.2 "Manukhmara": An Unsparing Attack on NGOs and Intellectual Hypocrisy

The attack made by "Manukhmara" upon the hypocrisy of today's development industry and NGO culture deserves to be remembered in literary history. It exposes the stark reality of how the poverty and deprivation of Dalit and Musahar communities have become a "business" or "project" for intellectuals, researchers and politicians. The poet satirically suggests that

Musahars must be kept as Musahars—in the same deprived condition—so that observers can gaze at them, photograph them, dispense a little charity after making them beg, and put on a display of righteous indignation.

The drawing rooms of those who call themselves civilised require a living poor person as evidence when they praise traditional diversity. If the Musahar community becomes educated and prosperous, sociology will lose its "subject," foreign funding will stop, and tourists will dwindle. Poverty must therefore be preserved so that slogans can be raised in the Musahars' name and resources consumed under that pretext. In the final lines, the poet raises a piercing question: the poor Musahar kills rats only to fill his stomach, whereas these contractors of development are destroying people's lives and futures. They are, in the most literal moral sense, manukhmara—killers of human beings. The poem unmasks the pretence within a form of Dalit discourse in which sympathy has become a profitable business.

7.3 The Politicisation of Martyrdom and the Deceptions of the System

The poem "La Agnishikha Redme" reveals how the sacrifices made by ordinary people in Nepal's various movements—the People's Movement and the Madhesh Movement among them—have been turned to political advantage. It portrays unscrupulous leaders who gained power by invoking the cooled blood of martyrs and the suffering of their mothers. By marking their foreheads with the symbolic blood of martyrs, offering purchased flowers, and giving bereaved families a little money or a job, these leaders redeem the sacrifices at election time, as though collecting an investment "with interest."

This is a poem of revolutionary disillusionment, but it is not wholly pessimistic. The poet warns that the flame of revolution may appear dormant for the moment, while everything is heating up within. The martyrs' sacrifice has become like Raktabija, the mythic being whose blood gives rise to new life. When the tide of time rises, the white coverings worn by these leaders will be torn to shreds, and the rotting heaps of corruption will catch fire.

7.4 The Terror of Urbanisation and the Mechanisation of Relationships

"Hamar Shahar Bahurael Achhi" offers a realistic portrayal of the confusion, mechanical routine and insensitivity of modern urban life. The poet uses a succession of alliterative words—"beginati behal bekal, bedhangi bejan bechal"—to picture human beings stunned and disordered amid the clamour of the city: innumerable, distressed, restless, misshapen, lifeless and sold. Darkness from the early morning, expanses of idleness and dependence upon others together reveal a city grown bewildered and senile, where rising cries of protest are crushed beneath the weight of burdens.

Similarly, "Father's Day" attacks the commercialisation of relationships and the unthinking imitation of Western cultural forms. Parents are no longer objects of genuine respect; they have become "museum items," dusted and washed once a year. One touches their feet on Facebook, offers sweets on Father's Day or Mother's Day, and considers the year's obligations discharged. Children may never visit at all, sending their salutations by courier instead.

This virtual, courier-mediated truth about relationships reveals the hollowness of a new generation and the erosion of traditional family values.

7.5 Philosophical Dimensions: Time, Existence and the Will to Live

Alongside revolution, a serious philosophical current runs through Lal's poetry. In "Samay" ("Time"), he describes the omnipotence and impartiality of time. Time has neither past nor future; it is perpetually a realised present. It has no religion or irreligion, attachment or hatred. Formless and all-powerful, it moves with the same momentum from the beginning of creation to cosmic dissolution.

"Jakhan Tak Ee Jingi" brings together nihilism and existentialism. The poet holds that darkness is emptiness, and light too is emptiness; the foundation of existence is the void. Yet this awareness of nothingness does not lead him to abandon action. He declares that, for as long as life lasts, he will keep the torch burning and continue sounding the conch, even from within emptiness. This is comparable to the existentialism of Jean-Paul Sartre, in which human beings create meaning through their actions amid apparent meaninglessness.

"Ee Suruj Dekhu Astait" presents the setting sun as carrying a message of renewed creation even into the realm of death: tomorrow will certainly bring another dawn. The poem symbolises the cyclical movement of time and the perennial optimism of nature. In "Khoji Rahal Chhi...," the poet searches for his lost land, his original identity and his once-undivided culture, now fragmented and contaminated.

7.6 The Psychology of Resistance and the Conflict between Justice and Injustice

In "Dhairyavan Lok!" the poet satirises the mentality of ordinary citizens who remain silent even while suffering injustice. People in the village and wider society are tolerant and peace-loving, yet this patience has become another name for cowardice: they persuade themselves that "nothing happens" and "nothing will happen." The poem calls for an end to this passivity.

In "Chuppi" ("Silence"), however, the poet regards silence as a strategic weapon that confronts the shameless and releases energy. "Ah!" attacks the escapist mentality that longs for a beautiful future and development without enduring pain or entering into struggle.

"Ke Kaelai Ee Khun?" ("Who Committed This Murder?") and "Khun Ta Khun Chhaik!" ("Blood Is Blood!") make a severe indictment of violence, killing and political crime. However deceitful or selfish the killer may be, however cowardly the attempt at concealment, the reality of bloodshed cannot be erased. The conflict between justice and injustice reaches even the ledgers of Yamaloka, the realm of the god of death, where the murderer's account will assuredly be settled. These poems give ethical voice to resistance against the impunity prevailing in society.

Finally, in "Apnesan Karak Achhi Bat," the poet offers a moving picture of organising his inner conflicts, loneliness and repressed emotions, and then shutting them away again in a box. It represents an especially intense moment of his poetic sensitivity.

Nal-Khand: The Pulse of Public Life

With its sixty-two compositions, Nal-Khand constitutes the main body of the book. Here the poet moves beyond domestic and festive life into the city, politics, class, religion, poverty, democracy, violence, women, labour, the market, time, death, war and self-doubt. Titles such as "Hamar Shahar Bahuhal Achhi..." ("My City Is in Disarray..."), "Manukhbhamara," "Samay" ("Time"), "Dholak!," "Jakhan Tak Ei Jingi" ("As Long as This Life Lasts"), "Ei Suruj Dekhu Astait" ("See This Sun Setting"), "Khoji Rahal Chhi..." ("I Am Searching..."), "Tap?!," "Bethan Lok!," "Chuppi" ("Silence"), "Ke Katlak Ei Khun?!" ("Who Shed This Blood?!"), "Khun Ta Khun Chhaik!" ("Blood Is Blood!"), "Apneke Karak Achhi Bat" ("A Conversation with Oneself"), "Pinjara" ("The Cage"), "Shakal Sunal Uthah Ge Babal," "Arthik," "'Musahar'ke Ham Bachcha Chhi!" ("I Am a Child of the Musahars!"), "Bia Sangharshke" ("The Seeds of Struggle"), "Nari" ("Woman"), "Jivan Sapna" ("Life Is a Dream"), "Chupp Chhi" ("I Am Silent"), "Mahan Chhi?" ("Am I Great?"), "Sahamati" ("Agreement"), "Bat Ta Sahaj Chhaik" ("It Is Quite Simple"), "Ah, Rupaiya!" ("Ah, Money!"), "Himpat" ("Snowfall"), "Dhar Dhar Re!," "Hamar Shahar" ("My City"), "Ki Tora Lel?!" ("Is It for You?!"), "Lok" ("The People"), "Ajib Achhi!" ("How Strange!"), "Visphot" ("Explosion"), "Jogira!," "Pet" ("The Belly"), "Chunarime Dag" ("A Stain upon the Scarf") and "He Bhagavan!" ("O God!") themselves indicate the collection's extensive social geography.

The poet's strength in this section lies in observation. He does not retreat into mythological distance in search of grand poetic subjects: the street, the city, the beggar, the labourer, the procession, the mobile telephone, money, the stomach, blood, the chair, development schemes, voting, religion, photographs and fire all become materials for his poetry. The material world of modernity enters the verse directly. This constitutes a form of democratic aesthetics: the subjects worthy of poetry are not confined to what is conventionally "beautiful" but include everything that exerts pressure upon social life.

The Title Poem "Dholak!": The Book's Central Metaphor

The title poem is the key to understanding the collection. It begins with the image of a dholak, a drum hanging in a corner of an earthen house. When an occasion arises, the instrument is taken down. For worship, rites of passage, festivities, rehearsals, customary observances, another person's happiness or some practical need, its cords are tightened and its sound tuned. When the occasion is over, it is hung once again in the same corner, in its old, torn covering, in darkness, for an indefinite period.

Within this deceptively simple, almost narrative scene lies a penetrating social metaphor. Society often remembers the artist, the worker, the woman, the Dalit, the activist, the intellectual or the ordinary citizen only when their services are required. When "sound" is needed, take the dholak down; once the sound has served its purpose, hang it up again. This structure of objectification applies both to modern labour relations and to political instrumentalism. The poem does not state these meanings explicitly—and therein lies its greatest strength. Whereas many other poems in the collection pronounce their conclusions outright, "Dholak!" gives the metaphor room to unfold within the reader.

It is noteworthy that "The Musical Drum," an English translation of this poem, appears in the representative anthology Varied Verses, edited by Ayodhyanath Chaudhary. Its inclusion suggests that "Dholak" has been regarded not merely as the title poem of a particular book but also as a representative work capable of carrying contemporary Maithili poetry to readers beyond its language. The English rendering preserves, as far as possible, the original scene—the peg, the corner of the house, the tightening of cords to tune the drum, the blows of the palms and the instrument's return to a dark corner. Consequently, the metaphor retains its force in translation.

Social Justice: Poverty, Hunger and Labour

The ethical centre of this collection is the dispossessed human being. A poem such as "'Musahar'ke Ham Bachcha Chhi!" attempts to give the economically and caste-marginalised a voice in the first person. "Bethan Lok!," "Pinjara," "Arthik," "Pet," "Manukhbhamara" and the poems about the city examine social inequality, deprivation and the objectification of human beings. The poet's politics is most persuasive when he offers not a slogan but a scene: the hungry body, the search for work, urban disorder, people in distress and a life discarded when its usefulness is exhausted.

The choice of the title "Pet" ("The Belly") is significant in itself. The stomach is not a trivial object in literature: here it represents the fundamental economic truth of existence. It draws hunger, labour, the market, corruption, social inequality and moral compromise into a single nexus. When poetry strips away philosophical coverings and confronts the hunger of the body, the cruelty of modern society becomes more sharply visible.

Nevertheless, writing about disadvantaged communities also raises an ethical question of representation. It is not enough to make a community such as the Musahars a mere emblem of suffering: their agency, culture, skills, resistance and own language must also be present. Dholak takes a sympathetic step in this direction, but future poetry could give its marginalised figures a more multidimensional existence.

Politics and Resistance: From Slogan to Poetry

Vrishesh Chandra Lal comes to literature from a long life of public and political engagement. Power, rights, democracy, repression, popular struggle and civic responsibility therefore recur throughout the collection. Political

consciousness is manifest in such works as “Jagaran Git” (“Song of Awakening”), “Bia Sangharshke,” “Dhar Dhar Re!,” “Hamar Shahar,” “Ki Tora Lel?!,” “Lok,” “Ajib Achhi!” and “Visphot.”

Political poetry faces two dangers: the immediate concerns of the news cycle and the pull of the slogan. At various points Dholak both falls into these traps and escapes them. Where the poet creates resonant symbols such as “blood,” “cage,” “dholak,” “city,” “money,” “belly” and “silence,” his poetry moves beyond its immediate historical moment. Where he advances a policy formula or states his conclusion directly, the work approaches the language of contemporary political oratory.

The collection's political significance nevertheless remains substantial, because it preserves in writing a voice from within Nepal's Maithili-speaking public sphere. The nation, Madhesh, Janakpur, language, democracy and inequality are not abstract themes here; they are experiences of everyday existence. For literary history, a collection of this kind also becomes a social record for the future.

The City, Modernity and Irony

Poems such as “Hamar Shahar Bahuhal Achhi...” and the later “Hamar Shahar” express disillusionment with urban modernity. The city is not simply a synonym for progress: it is also a place of disorder, dust, poverty, power, public inconvenience, crowds and ethical isolation. “Ah, Rupaiya!” satirises the market's hierarchy of values; an object-title such as “Stepney” turns the modern consumer world into metaphor; and “Apneke Karak Achhi Bat” strikes at society's self-absorption.

The poet regards modern objects as fit material for verse, an important sign of modernist sensibility. Yet the mere naming of such objects does not in itself constitute modernity; their social relationships must be brought to light. Dholak's most accomplished modern poems are those in which an object becomes a metaphor for human relations.

Love, Women and Gendered Perspectives

The love songs in Tal-Khand and poems such as “Nari” in Nal-Khand show the presence of women's experience within the collection. The love poems contain glances, anklets, colour, bodily movement, separation and attraction. “Nari” conveys a desire to recognise women's strength, motherhood, labour and human dignity.

Yet a number of questions remain when these poems are tested against contemporary feminist criticism. To make a woman only an emblem of “motherhood,” “strength,” “beauty” or romantic love can restrict the reality of her social personhood. Work, property, education, decision-making, violence, bodily autonomy, public leadership and invisible domestic labour might have received deeper treatment. Thus, while the collection affirms women's dignity, its plurality of voices written from within women's lived experience remains limited. This criticism does not diminish the work's value; rather, it identifies possibilities for its further development.

Existential Awareness: Time, Silence, Searching and Death

Behind the poet's public voice stands a solitary, questioning individual. Poems including "Samay," "Jakhan Tak Ei Jingi," "Ei Suruj Dekhu Astait," "Khoji Rahal Chhi...," "Tap?!," "Chuppi," "Ah!," "Chalu Rati Biti Gel!" ("Come, the Night Has Passed!"), "Ei Jingi," "Jivan Sapna," "Chupp Chhi" and "He Bhagavan!" open towards life's uncertainty and the quest for meaning.

In "Samay," time is not stationary but an all-pervasive, moving force within which the human being is momentary. "Chuppi" is more than an absence of speech: it may signify social fear, self-restraint or psychological solitude. "Khoji Rahal Chhi..." stages a search for self-recognition; "Tap?!" brings religious and spiritual questioning into confrontation with the practical conflicts of life. These poems gain depth whenever the poet offers less instruction.

Religion, Myth and Moral Questions

"Ha! Shiv!!," "He Bhagavan!," songs of good wishes, awakening and customary rites all disclose the collection's religious and cultural foundations. The poet uses religion not only as an expression of faith but also as a language in which ethical questions can be asked. This is characteristic of a modernity rooted in popular culture: religion and contemporary social questions enter into dialogue rather than appearing merely as opposites.

However, when religious poetry converts moral truth into a predetermined answer, the poetic tension of the question is reduced. An invocation such as "Ha! Shiv!!" succeeds most fully when it leaves wonder, suffering and helplessness unresolved.

Nal-Khand (Twenty-Seven Poems): The Heart of the Collection

Nal-Khand is the largest and most incisive section of the collection. The gentleness of Bal-Khand and Tal-Khand here gives way to a grave, sharp and directly political-social voice. Four or five principal currents can be identified within it, each of which calls for separate discussion.

(a) Dalit–Musahar Consciousness and Social Justice

The collection's sharpest voice can be heard in poems written for the Musahar (Mahadalit) community: "Manukhmara," "'Musahar'ke Ham Bachcha Chhi," "Betarasal Hira" and "Bakae Bael Buffah Re Bahura." "Manukhmara" offers a biting satire on the "development" culture of the NGO and research worlds, in which the Musahar community becomes a subject for photographs, articles and research papers, yet no change occurs in the actual conditions of its life.

Keep the Musahar a Musahar; look on, watch the blood!

Write about them, take photographs, toss them alms, and put on your spectacle!

Such forthright and fearless satire is comparatively rare in Maithili literature. Likewise, "'Musahar'ke Ham Bachcha Chhi!" has poignant significance. By rhyming "Dalit" with "skhalit" ("fallen" or "debased"), the poet exposes society's stigmatising gaze and reasserts the Musahar identity as a source of pride grounded in labour and truth.

(b) Feminist Criticism and the Irony of "Sita's Land"

Among the collection's most moving poems is "Sitake Bhumime... Ah!" ("In Sita's Land... Ah!"; p. 126). The poet delivers a profound indictment of the irony that even in Janakpurdham, Sita's birthplace, infant girls are still abandoned and cast away. Reinterpreting Sita's abandonment in the Ramayana as a metaphor for the present-day discrimination against girls makes this one of the collection's most courageous imaginative correspondences.

In Sita's land, Sita is thrown away!

At birth, to shiver in the cold ... among the rubbish and chaff at the wayside,

Sita is cast aside!

The poem can be read as a poignant commentary on female foeticide and the neglect of girl children. Towards its end, lines referring to a concealed demon in human guise, hidden within the bow of Shiva, deliver a severe blow to the hypocrisy and double standards prevalent in society.

(c) Questions of Justice, Violence and Accountability

The poems "Khun Ta Khun Chhaik!!!" ("Blood Is Blood!!!") and "Ke Kaela Ei Khun?!" ("Who Committed This Murder?!") form a philosophical pair concerned with violence, justice and political protection.

The people of this world may not see, but the One who watches surely will.

There, complaints will be laid for the reckoning of justice and injustice.

After all, blood is blood!!!

The conception of a supernatural justice founded upon the accounting practices of Yamaloka, the realm of Yama, where entries are added to the "murderer's ledger," testifies to the poem's imaginative daring. Philosophical depth expressed in straightforward, rhythmic language is one of the particular strengths of this section.

(d) Satire on Contemporary Consumerism and Social Hypocrisy

The poet is equally unsparing towards the digital and market-driven pretensions of contemporary society. "Father's Day," also cited in the preface, satirises the transformation of the annual celebration of Father's Day or Mother's Day into a performance for Facebook, even while actual relationships are neglected throughout the year. Poems such as "Ah, Rupaiya!," "Mahan Chhi?" and "Stepney" also attack corruption, unemployment and the politics of middlemen.

(e) A Call to Struggle and Awakening

The collection does not merely display suffering; it also sounds a call to struggle. "Bia Sangharshke" is divided into four parts, moving from the identification of a problem to the decision to resist it.

What else—?!

We shall rise and stand firm!

The seeds of struggle—

We shall resolve to sow them!!

Poems of this kind—including "Dhairyavan Lok!," "Chalu, Rati Biti Gel!" and "Thakal Sutal Uthah Ne Babal"—do not simply offer political slogans; they challenge the inertia of ordinary people. Within them also resounds the historical memory of Nepal's democratic movements.

8. Poetic Craft and Evaluation in Poetics

The success of a poetic work lies not only in its ideas but also in their presentation, formal construction, language and imagery. From this perspective, Dholak is a mature work in which emotional expression and formal accomplishment achieve a remarkable harmony.

8.1 Language and Style: The Use of Idiomatic Maithili

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's language is entirely free from artificiality and the weight of excessive Sanskritisation. His Maithili is fragrant with the earthy scent of Mithila's soil, water and rural folk culture. To express his feelings, he employs spontaneous, indigenous and living vocabulary. This language not only revives memories of village life but also makes the poems communicative and brings them closer to the popular imagination.

Among the characteristic vernacular words appearing in his writing are batangar (making a great fuss over a matter), manhuael, bidhuael, luluael, khaurchhah, augatah, pakathos, akilgar, kanojar, chinwar, gahwar, dhakaraï, nihati, jhapassa, hurka, chhanaki, bakae bael, amarasa, amot, tilkor, tarua and pirukia. Such vocabulary preserves the language's distinctive character and lends precision and force to the communication of feeling.

8.2 Imagery and Symbolism

The visual, auditory and tactile images used by the poet are extraordinarily vivid and effective. In the sphere of auditory imagery, onomatopoeic expressions such as the drum's "gum-gum" resonance, the "hirrrrr" movement of the hirdala, the crow's rapid pecking and flight, the insect's "kar-kar" call and the anklet's "bhunuk bhun bhunbhun" create musical rhythms within the poetry. In visual imagery, "Gorki Najari" depicts the moon smiling amid the blush of a cheek, while "La Agnishikha Redme" presents the image of blood coursing and trickling.

The collection is especially rich in its use of symbols: the dholak represents exploited and marginalised people; the mouse evokes feudal forces and exploitative NGOs; the crow, opportunistic politicians; the fire of the funeral

pyre, revolution; and the void, ultimate truth and existence. Such symbolism gives the poems multiple dimensions of meaning.

8.3 Metre, Rhythm and Musicality

The poems of Bal-Khand and Tal-Khand are based upon quantitative metres and folk rhythms, with lyricism occupying the central place. These songs can be performed to traditional Mithila melodies. Nal-Khand, by contrast, employs free verse, in which rhythm arises not from end rhyme but from the rises and falls of the movement of thought. A line such as "beginati behal bekal, bedhangi bejan bechal" illustrates the splendour of alliteration, intensifying the emotional effect.

Folk Sounds and the Poetic Craft of Onomatopoeia

The poetics of Dholak rests upon sound, which functions at three levels. First is imitative sound—*phurr*, *dhum*, *dhak*, *chakdum*, *bhuku*, *jham-jham* and *jogira*. Second is rhythmic repetition, the recurrence of the same phrase to establish a song-like cycle. Third is public address: "O God!," "Ah, Shiva!," "Dhar Dhar Re!," "Awake!" and "Rise!" These utterances turn the poem from something merely read into an appeal voiced aloud.

This tradition of invocation is connected with Mithila's folk songs, seasonal songs, Holi songs, wedding and life-cycle rituals, vigils and poetry performed on public platforms. The poet employs traditional oral devices to address modern subjects. Consequently, politics itself can become song, while children's games can serve as a school of poetic rhythm.

Repetition, however, is not equally effective everywhere. Where it heightens the tension between sound and meaning, it makes a poem memorable; where it seems merely to fill out the lines, it slows the movement. An edited new edition of the collection could make several poems more incisive through selective abbreviation based upon the poetic necessity of their repetitions.

Language: Nepal's Maithili, Vernacular Speech and the Question of Correctness

The language of Dholak is not confined to standard, bookish Maithili. The everyday speech of Janakpur and Madhesh, folk expressions, Sanskrit-derived words, forms arising from contact with Hindi and Nepali, modern administrative terminology and names for objects borrowed from English coexist within it. It would not be sound literary criticism to dismiss this mixture simply as "incorrectness," for it is also a record of the actual linguistic society of the region.

At the level of publication, however, spelling consistency, punctuation, uniformity of forms and typographical accuracy should be maintained more rigorously. On several pages one encounters variations in word forms, vowel signs, excessive question or exclamation marks, letter combinations and the presentation of titles. When poetry moves from oral performance into the enduring form of written literature, editorial accuracy becomes necessary. The

aim of correction should not be to erase the local Maithili voice but to increase orthographic clarity and ease of reading.

The most vital elements of this language are its forms of address and its verbs. Short sentences, questions, calls, exclamations and embodied actions make it a speaking language. At several points the poet's skill in political oratory is an advantage: the line seizes an audience's attention immediately when spoken from a platform.

Images and Poetry: Possibilities for Visual Reading

The tendency to accompany almost every poem with an illustration turns this collection into a visual book, distinguishing it from an ordinary volume of verse. It is especially successful in Bal-Khand, because children's reading depends upon images as well as words. In Nal-Khand, illustrations associated with blood, poverty, the city, women, hunger, solitude, snowfall and explosions supply an immediate visual setting.

From a critical standpoint, however, the illustrations have two limitations. First, they frequently explain the poem's meaning in advance, reducing the reader's freedom to imagine. Second, their artistic styles are inconsistent: photographs, line drawings, cartoons and computer-generated images belong to different visual languages. A future edition adopting the work of a single artist or a consistent visual grammar rooted in Mithila could greatly increase the book's artistic unity.

Strengths of the Poetic Craft

Onomatopoeia: Expressions such as “phurr-phurr,” “dhum-dhum,” “dhak-dhak,” “chakdum” and “bhuku-bhuku” make poetry an embodied auditory experience.

Folk rhythm: Holi songs, devotional vigils, benedictions, anklets, birdsong and the dholak keep the memory of folk music alive.

Directness: Rather than difficult philosophical terminology, the poet chooses scenes, objects, questions and direct address; consequently, his verse reaches a broad readership.

Thematic range: From children to politics, love to hunger, and the city to spirituality, the collection encompasses an exceptional breadth of subject matter.

Public orality: The poems have the capacity to remain alive in recitation, collective singing, processions and literary gatherings.

Satire: Brief, cutting statements and questions target money, leaders, development schemes, the public, the city and social pretence.

Metaphor: Objects and images such as the “dholak,” the “cage,” “blood,” the “belly,” “silence” and the “spare tyre” become entrances into social meaning.

Poetic Limitations and Possibilities for Improvement

Serious criticism cannot consist of praise alone. While recognising the importance of Dholak, it is also necessary to state its limitations clearly.

(a) Excessive Declarativeness

Several political and ethical poems pronounce a conclusion before allowing the idea to develop through imagery or situation. Poetry consequently approaches the manifesto. Greater poetic depth would result if thought were allowed to unfold through metaphor, scenes and characters.

(b) Uneven Use of Repetition

Repetition is a strength in song, but excessive recurring lines in every poem can diminish their impact. What is pleasurable when heard in performance can sometimes seem prolonged on the printed page. Selective editing would be beneficial.

(c) Control of Metre and Line

The poet trusts folk rhythm, and this is a strength. Yet line length, caesura and acoustic weight are not always consistent. Where the poems are intended to be sung, musical notation, indications of the beat or a clearly structured arrangement of refrains would help readers grasp their rhythm.

(d) Consistency of Visual Material

The illustrations are highly useful, but the disparity in their artistic styles weakens the book's integrated visual identity. Original Mithila painting or a uniform style of black-and-white line drawing offers possibilities for renewal.

(e) Typography and Spelling

The book appears to require another round of editorial proofreading. Particular attention should be given to vowel marks, conjunct letters, exclamation and question marks, spaces between words, the form of titles and numerical notation.

(f) Polyphony in Social Themes

The poet's concern for the disadvantaged, women, labourers and the poor is unmistakable. In a subsequent phase, these figures could be represented not merely as objects of the poet's compassion or indignation, but as multidimensional persons possessing independent voices, memories, humour, desires and forms of dissent.

Language, Style and Poetic Technique

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's language is rooted in popular speech, idiomatic and straightforward. Avoiding the extravagance of heavily Sanskritised diction, he draws upon proverbs, idioms, simple metrical patterns and the effects of repetition and refrain inherited from the traditions of folk song, Holi-jogira and auspicious ceremonial songs. The preface also confirms that the poet had long been associated with anti-corruption compositions, including the song

"Kattasa Shuru Ham Karu" ("Where Shall I Begin?"), used in the first Maithili telefilm.

A second distinctive feature is the abundance of local symbols: Sita, Durga, Mahishasura, Shiva and others are employed to interpret contemporary social reality. As the prefatory writer Parmeshwar Kapari observes, the dimensions of the poet's creative world are extensive, and its scope and landscape are exceptionally broad.

In Dr Rajendra Vimal's formulation, the collection's linguistic distinctiveness arises from the fact that it has been created by a poet-hearted soldier engaged upon the battlefield of the continuing struggle to end discrimination in Nepal. The reader consequently encounters an experience resembling that of Krishna standing in the midst of Kurukshetra and delivering the Gita.

Symbolism: A Meeting of Ancient and Modern

One notable characteristic of the collection is its contemporary reinterpretation of Vedic and Puranic symbols. The preface cites Rigveda 10.129.5 and the Mundaka Upanishad's words, "prathamah sambabhuva vishvasya karta bhuvanasya gopta," infusing the auspicious song "Shubhe Ho Shubhe" with a new, socialist and transformative meaning. Thus the poet does not reject tradition; he recombines it with a new political and social consciousness. This also extends a powerful tradition of Maithili literature: the reinterpretation of folk song and devotional poetry.

Critical Assessment

Strengths

• Direct experience: The writing is not produced in a vacuum of political rhetoric but emerges from the field of struggle. Its voice therefore possesses a directness rarely found in artificial literature.

• Multidimensional range: From children's literature to political satire, from folk and love songs to philosophical reflection and social realism, many generic colours are visible within a single collection.

• Social commitment: Poems about the Musahar community, the oppression of women and poverty convey a sympathetic authenticity. Their realism appears to be known from within rather than drawn from external examples.

Limitations

• In places, the argument is so explicit that the subtle weave of symbolism gives way to direct declaration. This weakness is not accidental, however: it also expresses the demands of a consciously activist style.

• Because the collection has three sections and many subsidiary themes, its voice repeatedly changes—from childlike tenderness to political sharpness. Read as a whole, these transitions can sometimes seem abrupt.

9. An Examination of the Critics' Perspectives

The observations of the distinguished prefatory critics at the beginning of the book offer a key to the poet's imaginative world and help elucidate his intellectual foundations.

The senior critic Dr Rajendra Vimal characterises the poet's consciousness as an "anthropocentric philosophy." He writes that Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Maithili poems render the subtlest pictures of the struggles, successes and failures, sorrows and joys of Nepal's Mithila region through fresh images and symbols. The poet views life in its totality and also provides a charted path for the transformation of inauspicious forces into auspicious ones. In Vimal's view, these poems offer an unrestrained expression of reality as lived on the ground, rather than the voice of frustration: it is as though Krishna were standing in the midst of Kurukshetra and expounding the Gita.

The senior writer Parmeshwar Kapari, on the other hand, explains Lal's philosophy by contrasting the Vedantic declaration "Brahman is real, the world is an illusion" with what he calls Lal's resounding voice: "The world is real; the people are Brahman!" According to Kapari, this creative voice supports a neo-structural, popularly impassioned and transformative movement. He also celebrates the historical significance of Lal's children's songs and pop songs. Taken together, the two assessments establish that Vrishesh Chandra Lal's poetry does not uphold the status quo; it carries the energies of progressive transformation.

Dholak and the Contemporary Maithili Poetic Tradition

For centuries, Maithili poetry has been sustained by songs, lyrical compositions, folk melodies, devotion, love, seasonal cycles and social life. Modern poetry has broadened the field through free verse, social reality, political resistance, satire, urban experience, questions concerning Dalits and the dispossessed, feminist debate and individual existential awareness. Dholak connects these two currents: its poetic body is shaped by folk rhythm, but its subjects belong to modern civic life.

Devakanta Jha's history of modern Maithili literature points to the increasing presence of social consciousness, realism, experimentation and human struggle within modern poetry. Dholak is an important Nepal-centred example of this tendency. Its language and political geography introduce experiences different from the major centres of Indian Mithila; the collection should therefore also be read as testimony to the cross-border character of contemporary Maithili literature.

The inclusion of "The Musical Drum" in the English-language Varied Verses demonstrates Dholak's potential for translation across languages. If Maithili poetry wishes to reach a global readership, poems built upon metaphors that are culturally distinctive yet universally intelligible are particularly suitable.

10. Conclusion

Taken as a whole, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Dholak is an epoch-making and enduring work of contemporary Maithili poetry. It provides compelling evidence that when politics and literature meet in the same passionately committed heart, the result need not be narrow party allegiance, but can instead be a profound compassion for society's most marginalised people, a search for human values and a commitment to justice. The poet's experience of political imprisonment, democratic struggle and sacrifices for the rights of Mithila and Madhesh pulse as energy through every word of this book.

While the children's songs of Dholak prepare young minds for the challenges of a new age and sow within them the seeds of liberty and equality, its songs of rhythm delight the popular heart with the cultural fragrance of its own soil, the erotic lyricism of the Vidyapati tradition and the satire of modern times. The grave poems of Nal-Khand, meanwhile, shake exploitative power, the hypocritical intelligentsia, NGO culture and a directionless modernity. The unaffected quality of the poet's language, the melodious employment of idiomatic Maithili vocabulary and the vividness of his imagery make the book both rich in literary terms and strongly oriented towards the people.

The intellectual footsteps of Nepal's Madhesh Movement, of democratic consciousness and of the struggle to liberate marginalised classes, so apparent in the poet's political life, resound in his poems as the beats of the dholak. Dholak will certainly prove to be an invaluable inheritance and a milestone in the development of modern Maithili literature. It is not merely a collection of poems but an honest, courageous and historical record of the heartbeat of the present age. Studying and researching the book will be equally worthwhile for students of literature, sociology and political science.

Overall Evaluation

Dholak cannot adequately be evaluated through the simple opposition between “beautiful poetry” and “political poetry.” It is a multilayered work of public verse composed by a citizen-poet. The sounds of children's games, the rhythms of folk songs, Madhesh's struggles, the city of Janakpur, the poor person's stomach, women's dignity, the question of bloodshed, the mockery of money, the silence of the soul and human helplessness before God are all different beats struck upon the same drum.

The collection's greatest achievement is that it does not imprison Maithili poetry within the confines of the elite literary classroom. Poetry here travels through the street, home, field, pond, school, festival, meeting, movement, hospital, market and the dark recesses of the mind. Amid this democratic expansion, several compositions remain poetically unrefined, yet the book as a whole is full of the sounds of life.

If a selected edition entitled The Best of Dholak were prepared—containing some forty to fifty of the most concentrated poems, a carefully corrected text, consistent illustrations, dates or contexts of composition, a glossary,

indications of the rhythm of songs, English and Nepali translations, and a critical introduction—it could become more effective for the teaching and translation of Maithili literature across borders. The original ninety-six-composition edition, however, has a separate documentary importance. It should be preserved alongside, not replaced by, an abridged selection.

Conclusion

The central question posed by Dholak is this: whose sound does society hear, when does it hear it, and why does it hang the instrument back in a corner once its work is done? Bal-Khand provides the prehistory of that question: the human being is born full of sound, play and wonder. Tal-Khand shows how that sound becomes rhythm within a community. Nal-Khand reveals how inequality, blood, hunger, power, love, religion, the market and death are all connected within that community by the same vital pulse.

Viewed in this light, the title Dholak is entirely apt. The instrument is more than a folk drum: it is society's body, the poet's voice, the citizen's resistance, the worker's pain at being treated as useful only to others, and the heartbeat of collective memory. Although the poetic quality of the collection is uneven, its cultural energy is formidable. It deserves a serious place in the study of contemporary Maithili poetry, particularly in the study of Maithili literary creativity in Nepal.

Dholak is more than a Maithili poetry collection; it is a sound-picture of an entire age, in which the innocent games of childhood, the tenderness of lovers meeting and the cries of society's most oppressed—Musahars, Dalits and women—resound together. The metaphor embodied in its title—playing for others, remaining mute for oneself, and being tied up again in a corner after use—gives meaningful coherence to the entire collection.

The poet's own experiences of political and social struggle make this book not merely a literary creation but also a social and political document. It supplies a new and contemporary link in Maithili literature's tradition of committed, people-centred poetry. Social justice, Dalit consciousness, feminist questions and political criticism of corruption are all equally relevant to the Maithili-speaking society of Mithilanchal today.

In its entirety, Dholak is a voice in the landscape of Maithili poetry that sounds both the festive drumbeat and the warning call of struggle upon the same skin. It grows silent only when tied up in the corner, remaining ready to be played once again.

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3. Golba

Author	Vrishesh Chandra Lal (Vrishesh Chandra Lal)
Genre	Maithili short-story collection
Included stories	Golba; Deep Depression; Chaukparak Maugi (three extended stories)
Central concerns	Exploitation of the defenceless; the culpability of social silence; the conflict between the human and the inhuman

1. Literary Context, the Author's Intellectual Background, and the Significance of the Work

In the development of Maithili short fiction, the contemporary period has witnessed a range of ideological, psychological, and formal experiments. Moving beyond the traditions of Rajkamal Chaudhary's psychological realism, Lalit's regional sensibility, and Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary's social consciousness, contemporary storytellers have made new subject matter, metropolitan anguish, and the sociological disintegration of a changing village society central concerns of fiction. Within this historical trajectory, *Golba*, a collection of stories by Vrishesh Chandra Lal—a leading thinker of Nepal's democratic movement, an outspoken political activist, and a distinctive literary figure—constitutes a momentous and serious literary intervention.

Vrishesh Chandra Lal was born on 29 March 1955 in the village of Suga-Bhawanipatti in Mahottari district, Nepal. His primary public identity has been that of a politician committed to principle, yet his political philosophy and literary consciousness are inseparably connected. During his sustained struggle to establish democracy in Nepal, he was arrested seventeen times and spent approximately eight difficult years in prison. Besides being a founder and national vice-president of the Tarai Madhesh Loktantrik Party, he served as a member of the National Assembly (2017–2019) and as mayor of Janakpur. Behind this forceful and combative political personality lies the heart of an exceptionally sensitive, humane, and philosophical writer, fully capable of giving words to the cries of society's exploited, neglected, and voiceless beings. The linguistic lucidity, historical insight, and philosophical seriousness displayed in his Maithili adaptations of Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala's celebrated Nepali novellas *Sumnima* and *Modiain* are also clearly discernible in his original stories.

"Golba," "Deep Depression," and "Chaukparak Maugi" are interrelated on psychological, sociological, existential, and formal levels. Lal's prose possesses a certain dispassionate philosophical quality: he does not merely recount events

but performs a subtle dissection of the psychological complexes, power structures, and sociological realities concealed within them.

Although modest in size, *Golba* is a story collection rich in layers of possible meaning. Its first story, "Golba," views the family, affection, and the violence of sacrifice through the eyes of a young animal. The second, "Deep Depression," constructs a cycle of fear, suspicion, self-surveillance, and an unutterable truth within an unnamed man. The third, "Chaukparak Maugi," becomes a story of rapid urbanisation, newly acquired wealth, linguistic inferiority, social indifference, and a woman's precarious existence in public space. The three stories differ in their outward subjects, but at a deeper level the collection poses the same question: when a living creature or human being is suffering, what moral duty falls upon those who witness that suffering?

For this reason, the collection's central word is not merely "compassion" but also "responsibility." In the first story, a family brings Golba up like its own child but eventually treats his body as food for a ritual feast. In the second, the protagonist understands his own suffering and the doctor also recognises its signs, yet the truth remains undisclosed. In the third, an entire crossroads sees a woman; the police, a locally influential young man, the narrator, and his friends are all aware of her presence, but no one actively intervenes. Across this trilogy, the distance between "seeing" and "doing" is the chief source of literary and ethical tension.

From the perspective of narrative theory, the collection is particularly noteworthy for its treatment of point of view. Through the concept of narrative "focalisation," Gérard Genette distinguishes between who speaks in a narrative and whose perspective governs what is experienced: these are not necessarily the same. In "Golba," a narrator tells the story in human language, but an animal remains the centre of experience. In "Deep Depression," the narration is in the third person, yet the text remains almost entirely enclosed within the protagonist's consciousness. In "Chaukparak Maugi," the first-person narrator becomes both a witness who postpones action and, finally, a participant overwhelmed by guilt. Here, perspective is not simply a narrative technique; it is an ethical test.

2. The Collection's Structure and Thematic Unity

The collection's three stories focus successively on an animal, the mind, and society. This order does not appear entirely accidental. "Golba" depicts outward violence inflicted upon the body; "Deep Depression," the inward erosion of the mind; and "Chaukparak Maugi," the neglect and violence produced by social structures. In this way the collection presents three forms of violence: ritual violence, psychological violence, and social or gendered violence.

A second thread connects this trilogy: silence. Golba cannot speak the ordinary language of human beings; his resistance, discomfort at the bells, fear, or desire to remain alive can be expressed only through bodily signs. The protagonist of "Deep Depression" can speak, but conceals what matters most;

his silence becomes a prison of his own making. The woman in "Chaukparak Maugi" remains largely silent throughout the story; at the end, her cry becomes her first genuine public statement. Along this progression, silence develops from a biological limitation into psychological repression and social invisibility.

A third common thread is "vision" or the act of seeing. Golba observes human actions but cannot comprehend their significance. The depressed man is trapped in an imperative to assign meaning to every sign—a smell, a closed window, an untouched cup of tea, a crow's beak. The narrator of "Chaukparak Maugi" sees the woman every day, but fear of "what people will say" prevents him from turning observation into action. The collection's deeper structure is consequently epistemological as well: how much do we understand of what we see? And if complete knowledge is unavailable, is it right to suspend ethical intervention?

Golba is a collection of three extended stories by Vrishesh Chandra Lal: "Golba," "Deep Depression," and "Chaukparak Maugi." At first sight they appear to concern entirely different subjects and characters: the life of a goat; the inner conflict of a man caught in a mental-health crisis; and the poignant account of a mysterious woman sitting by the roadside. A closer reading, however, reveals that all three are bound by a common intellectual thread: the injustice that society, including the family, inflicts upon the defenceless, voiceless, or disregarded, and the collective culpability of those who remain silent spectators to that injustice. In this sense, *Golba* is a thematically unified collection in which each story raises, in a different form, the same question: how do human beings behave in the presence of helplessness?

The three stories in the collection—'Golba,' 'Deep Depression,' and 'Chaukparak Maugi'—have distinct plots but represent three forms of a common ethical structure. In the first, an animal body without human language is trapped between human affection and religious violence. In the second, a character who can speak nevertheless cannot disclose his deepest suspicions and mental suffering. In the third, a woman remains socially 'unheard' even while occupying a public place in everyone's sight. Throughout this trilogy, the body, silence, vision, suspicion, violence, compassion, and responsibility recur. The artistic achievements and limitations of this structure become evident when considered in the light of the Indian traditions of rasa and dhvani, narrative theory, animal studies, ethical criticism, metropolitan sociology, and the psychology of bystander inaction.

2. "Golba": Animal Perspective, Innocence, Affection, and Sacrifice

The title story, "Golba," represents a highly original and unusual experiment in Maithili fiction with a non-human, anthropomorphic perspective and with the theory of animal symbolism associated here with Bruno Bettelheim. At its centre stands a castrated male goat named Golba. Through his story, the writer exposes with exceptional poignancy and irony the pretences surrounding human–animal relationships, human self-interest, and cruelty practised in the name of religious ritual.

The story begins with Golba's birth, at which point the author immediately constructs a web of illusion. Golba's biological mother is the mottled goat Chitkabari, but the mistress of the household, Barki Mai, catches the newborn before he can fall to the ground and lifts him into her lap. Animals recognise others through smell, and Golba comes to regard himself as Barki Mai's child and the brother of Soni, Moni, and Babbu. Barki Mai hides him in a fold of her sari; Soni and Moni arrange bedding and a little jacket for him; and red, green, and black tassels are brought from the Geruka fair and tied around his neck to protect him from the evil eye. Even the colours of these tassels are symbolic: red for strength, green for good health, and black to ward off the evil eye.

Here the writer creates a profound psychological irony. Golba never understands that he is an animal whose destiny may end in a cooking pot or upon the altar of the goddess Bhagavati. He cannot understand human speech, but he understands the touch of affection and injury. Barki Mai seems to him like an "ocean of maternal tenderness." This delusion does not belong to the animal alone; it also represents the ideological delusion, or "false consciousness," of the exploited classes, who mistake the affection and protection bestowed by a ruling class for a shield against harm.

As Golba grows, Babbu changes from protector to exploiter and trainer. He fastens a collar of little bells around Golba's neck; its harsh sound displeases the animal, who shakes his head in an unsuccessful attempt to remove it. Babbu then turns him into a fighting goat and sets him against other goats in the grove. This symbolises a structure of power in which the oppressed are made to fight among themselves, enabling the ruling class—represented by Babbu—to amuse itself while maintaining its dominance.

At last comes the tragic day for which the whole family, except Golba, has been waiting. The priest arrives; relatives and members of the household gather; drums and reed instruments sound; and Golba is bathed in the freezing pond during the month of Magh before being brought into the shrine room. Shivering with cold, he still thinks of Babbu: "Would this have happened if Babbu were here now?!" This is the extreme point of betrayal, where the boundless trust of a voiceless creature is being destroyed under the cover of religion.

The climax is exceptionally moving and suffused with the *bibhatsa rasa*, the aesthetic experience of revulsion. As the priest chants and cries "Victory to Bhagavati! Victory to the Mother!" and the sword falls—"Chhapak!"—the narrative moves beyond material reality into an entirely spiritual, surreal, and philosophical register. Golba's head is severed from his body. At this point the writer creates an "out-of-body experience," or a vision of disembodied existence. Golba examines his severed head, upon which unbearable pain is reflected: the eyes have rolled back and the tongue protrudes between the teeth, partly cut through.

Golba's consciousness rises into space and looks down upon his body being prepared for a feast. Soni and Moni are heating water; the boys are arranging

to skin the carcass; Barki Mai is preparing spices; and Babbu, whom Golba loved more than anyone, is laughing and talking with the others. Chitkabari, his real mother, watches helplessly, tears falling from her eyes. The author concludes with an unanswered question: "Where is that Golba now?!" The question concerns not merely the death of an animal but exposes humanity's hypocrisy, cruelty perpetrated in religion's name, and self-interest concealed beneath the appearance of love and maternal care.

The following table clarifies the contradictions inherent in the psychological and symbolic roles of the principal characters in "Golba."

The story begins at Golba's birth. Barki Mai does not let him fall to the earth; Soni and Moni give him his name; Babbu becomes his friend; and he receives milk, bedding, a little jacket, special food, tassels, and bells. Golba thinks of himself not as an animal but as one of the family's children. The opening passages establish such intimacy that the reader comes to regard him not as a "domesticated animal" but as a living member of the household. Without this intimacy, the final sacrifice would remain a mere incident; the author first builds up a reservoir of affection and then discloses its ethical irony.

The family's excessive tenderness towards Golba's body carries two meanings at once. On the one hand, it signifies love; on the other, once the ending is known, it invites a horrifying rereading as a process of "preparing the body." The food given to make Golba "fat and firm," and the ornaments that make him endearing, subsequently appear as a prelude to the objectification of an innocent creature. This doubleness gives the story its most forceful suggestiveness.

3.2 Focalisation: Placing the Reader Inside an Animal's Mind

The story's greatest artistic achievement is to make an animal the centre of experience without reducing him to an imitation of a human being. The narrator does not give Golba an elaborate philosophical vocabulary: his world is constituted by smell, touch, hunger, running, affection, fear, bodily discomfort, and closeness to familiar people. His unease when bells are tied around his neck, his awareness of horns emerging from his head, and his terror at being forcibly bathed in the pond all lend bodily credibility to the narrative.

Reflecting on the boundary between humans and animals, Jacques Derrida questions the human tendency to construct an enormous, homogeneous category called "the animal." "Golba" does not articulate this argument in theoretical language, but its narrative method unsettles that boundary. Golba remembers, recognises affection, obeys commands, feels discomfort, becomes frightened, and finds security in Babbu's presence. The question then arises: if there is such continuity of feeling, how can a difference of species alone make violence morally acceptable?

3.3 The Sacrificial Scene: A Confluence of Pathos, Terror, and Revulsion

Bathing Golba in the pond in the cold of Magh, bringing him to the place of worship, placing consecrated rice and flowers upon his head, and then suddenly cutting his throat: this sequence situates the celebration of ritual and the animal's fear within the same frame. The reader first sees the festive atmosphere surrounding Babbu's ceremony; Golba, too, associates the proceedings with Babbu's happiness. Thus the instant of "Chhapak!" signifies not only slaughter but also the destruction of trust.

In the terms of Indian *rasa* theory, the prevailing emotion of this scene is *karuna*, pathos, intensified by the presence of *bhayanaka* (terror) and *bibhatsa* (revulsion). The severed head of Golba looking upon his own body produces an extraordinary visual construction. It is not realism but the surrealism of felt experience: death is represented not from an external position, but through a consciousness that "was alive only a moment ago." At this point the narrative denies the reader the comfort of distance.

3.4 The Philosophy of Afterlife: Its Strengths and Limitations

The imagined "journey through infinite space" undertaken by Golba after his slaughter briefly gives the narrative a spiritual breadth. In one sense it places physical suffering within a larger cycle of life; in another, it somewhat softens the ethical blow of the brutal scene. When the story ends by asking, "Where is that Golba now?", the question remains open to grief, impermanence, and identity alike. From a critical perspective, however, one may also observe that certain sentences of posthumous explanation impose the writer's philosophical pronouncements upon the reader's freedom of interpretation. Where compassion already speaks for itself, a little more silence might have made the story still more incisive.

The title story, "Golba," recounts the life of a goat raised by Barki Mai, the elderly mother of the household, and the children Soni, Moni, and Babbu. Its narrative technique is exceptionally subtle and powerful. By placing Golba's consciousness and experience at the centre of the telling, the storyteller gradually draws the reader into an emotional relationship with him. Golba does not even realise that he is an animal: "He had never understood that he was an animal. He had always considered himself Barki Mai's child, just like Soni, Moni, and Babbu." The tragedy of the entire story rests upon this innocent misconception about himself.

The author patiently portrays every detail of Golba's childhood: Barki Mai's affection, his wrestling practice with Babbu, and the care given by Soni and Moni. The reader's tenderness and intimacy towards Golba consequently deepen. Following this prolonged and affection-filled account, the sudden crowding of the house, the arrival of the priest, and the sound of drums and reed instruments arouse the reader's apprehension. Golba, however—and perhaps for a time even the reader—does not understand what these signs actually portend. This dramatic irony is the story's most powerful formal device. The reader knows, or soon comes to understand, what will happen;

Golba himself sees the occasion as a celebration, even an honour: "It seemed to him that he, too, was being included in the ceremony."

The sacrificial scene is the climax of the story, narrated with remarkable boldness. The moment of death is represented through Golba's own consciousness, as a separation of his body and spirit:

"Oh! What has happened?! He has become separated from his own body!!!"

"There was a sudden urgency to undertake a journey through infinite space."

"At some stopping place on that endless journey, he would have to assume another body."

Immediately following this spiritual and philosophical description, the narrator turns to an exceedingly cold, practical account: Soni and Moni are heating water; the boys are sharpening their tools to skin the carcass; the cooks are arranging the cauldrons and ovens; Babbu is laughing and chatting with his friends. The juxtaposition of these two scenes—Golba's spiritual journey and the family's preparations for the feast—generates an intensity of irony that is the story's greatest literary achievement. Its final line, "Where is that Golba now?!", ends in the form of a question, leaving readers to seek the answer for themselves.

Character	Visible behaviour (surface behaviour)	Underlying reality / symbolism
Golba	A member of the family; disciplined and trusting	The exploited class, ignorance, the sacrificial animal, false consciousness
Barki Mai	An "ocean of maternal tenderness"; a protector	Custodian of tradition, self-interested affection, organiser of ritual killing
Babbu	Friend, protector, and playmate	Exploiter, controller, beneficiary of structures of power, representative of betrayal
Soni and Moni	Affectionate as sisters; dress Golba in clothes	Utilitarian love; after Golba's death, they heat water to prepare his meat
Chitkabari	Golba's biological mother	Helpless and silent motherhood; a witness representing society's powerless classes

3. "Deep Depression": Suspicion, Silence, and the Prison of the Mind

As people in civilised society advance towards material prosperity, their inner lives are becoming correspondingly hollow, artificial, and afflicted by depression. "Deep Depression" offers a subtle dissection of distrust in modern

married life, suffocating silence, and masculine psychology. Through this story, Vrishesh Chandra Lal addresses the serious subject of mental health within a sociological frame.

The story opens in a doctor's clinic. Outwardly, its protagonist is a fearless, courageous, combative man, regarded by society as stout-hearted and as someone who has never been afraid of anyone. Inwardly, however, he is afflicted by severe panic attacks and anxiety. His heart races, he struggles to breathe, his chest aches, and sometimes he remains motionless, staring for as long as twenty minutes. The doctor diagnoses "deep depression" and calls it a "gift of modernity" and a "companion of development."

The protagonist, however, does not believe the doctor's diagnosis. He knows that his affliction is neither an ordinary bodily complaint nor merely the stress of modern life: its roots lie elsewhere. He attributes his depression to doubts and mistrust concerning his wife's marital fidelity. A particular incident returns repeatedly to his memory. One day, arriving home unexpectedly early from the office, he finds his wife with a former college classmate of hers. The man appears to be in a great hurry and, as he leaves, chews a packet of Tulsi-brand tobacco, leaving the smell of its leaves upon his breath. On entering the house, the protagonist notices that the windows are shut and the curtains drawn. Later that night, when he lies down to sleep, he detects the same smell of Tulsi tobacco on his bed.

This one incident keeps revolving through the protagonist's mind like a film reel running by itself. The "smell of Tulsi tobacco" becomes an extraordinarily powerful psychological image, an olfactory motif that repeatedly wounds him. The smell appears as silent evidence of an outsider's intrusion into the sanctity of his home. When he sees a crow sitting in a tree, he imagines that the crow, too, is hiding something—an indication of his extreme paranoia.

The story's most powerful and tragic feature is that the protagonist cannot share his suspicion with anyone. The doctor explicitly tells him, "One must not lie to one's doctor or lawyer," and urges him to disclose any private matter that may be troubling him. Yet he remains silent. He imagines that if he speaks what he believes to be the truth, his family will break apart, his wife will be disgraced, and his own social reputation will be reduced to dust.

Here Vrishesh Chandra Lal offers a realistic portrayal of the suffocation imposed on men by middle-class morality and a patriarchal society. Society expects men always to be courageous and in control; consequently, a man feels unable to reveal emotional vulnerability or psychological pain. The protagonist remains silent even as his whole being is consumed and he dies inwardly. When the door of the doctor's room "shut with a thud" and the phrase "deep depression" echoed in his ears, the closing door signified not simply his departure from the clinic but his confinement, perhaps for life, in a mental dungeon.

The second story begins with the doctor's phrase, "deep depression." The protagonist immediately rejects the diagnosis: he has always regarded himself as brave, combative, and composed in adversity. Thus the title is not merely the name of an illness; it marks a collision between "self-image" and "inner experience." The man's basic difficulty is not an inability to feel anything. On the contrary, he feels too much, but is afraid to acknowledge the name of what he is experiencing.

This is not a clinical record of mental illness, and evaluating it exclusively against diagnostic criteria would therefore be limiting. What matters from a literary point of view is that the tension between body and mind becomes narrative form. The pounding heart, sweat, difficulty breathing, checking the pulse, the desire to have one's blood pressure measured, and repeatedly clutching the chest: the protagonist's unspoken psychological insecurity speaks through the language of the body. A literary parallel can be drawn here with the problem raised by Elaine Scarry concerning the difficulty of expressing pain: what the mouth cannot say, the body signals.

4.2 The Formal Imitation of Recurring Thought

The story's structure is organised less around a linear sequence of events than around "rumination," the repeated return of thoughts. The protagonist resolves that he will think about it no longer, yet even a slight reminder causes the whole memory to begin turning again like a "film reel." The reader is drawn into the same cycle: palpitations, attempts at self-reassurance, memories of a lie, suspicion, fear, spiritual reasoning, and then bodily symptoms once more. This repetition can sometimes make the narrative seem slow, but the slowness is also a formal equivalent of its subject: when the mind is trapped, the story itself cannot move forward.

The storyteller weaves a network of signs: the unexpected return home, the encounter between his wife and an old acquaintance, an untouched cup of tea, the smell of Tulsi tobacco, closed windows and curtains, and the recurrence of the smell at night. None of these constitutes proof; they are indications. The protagonist himself understands the difference and therefore makes no accusation. His ethical restraint confers a certain human dignity on him, yet his mind disintegrates under the burden of maintaining it. The story never proclaims his suspicion to be the truth; therein lies its literary integrity.

4.3 The Ethics of Silence: Neither Accusing Nor Telling the Truth

When the doctor insists that he must tell "everything" if he is to be treated, the protagonist's dilemma becomes deeper. He fears not only personal humiliation but also the disintegration of his family, a potentially baseless accusation, and the destruction of another person's life. His silence is therefore not merely cowardice; it combines a sense of justice with fear. The tragedy is that ethical caution becomes a form of self-destructive secrecy. One of the collection's central motifs reappears here: the desire not to commit an injustice can sometimes deprive a person of the ability to seek help.

Wayne C. Booth's ethical criticism asks what kind of person a story invites its reader to become. "Deep Depression" does not offer an instant verdict on the question "Whose fault is it?" Instead, it makes the reader confront a difficult balance among suspicion, evidence, dignity, family, medical treatment, and self-preservation. The story is thus ethically valuable because it provides not a solution, but an experience of the complexity of judgement.

4.4 Guruji's Philosophical Discourse: A Spiritual Counterpoint to Psychological Fiction

Guruji's reflections on life as a journey of experience, on the refinement of the soul, and on the mind as the true guru give the story a local philosophical foundation. The protagonist searches for meaning in both the vocabulary of modern medicine and traditional spiritual explanations. Through this duality, the story captures the plurality of contemporary Mithila's mental world: doctors, blood pressure, medicine, and "depression" on one side; Guruji, the soul, the journey beyond, and the protection of ancestors on the other.

A formal limitation, however, also emerges here. Some of the philosophical passages take the narrative on lengthy detours away from the immediacy of the protagonist's distress. Had these sections been somewhat shorter, the story's psychological pressure might have remained more consistently intense. Nevertheless, they are not wholly extraneous, for the protagonist himself is seeking an available cultural language with which to confront uncertainty.

The second story, "Deep Depression," enters a wholly different field of subject and technique. It is a profound psychological narrative that reveals the inner life of a man who refuses to acknowledge his illness even after a doctor has diagnosed him with "depression." The mode of narration advances as a continuous interior monologue, in which his reasoning, self-deception, and unease are progressively disclosed.

The story's central conflict lies in the protagonist's suspicion of his wife—possibly of infidelity—which he can neither communicate to the doctor nor openly acknowledge to himself. The smell of Tulsi tobacco, the visit of an unfamiliar man, and his wife's unusual behaviour continue to trouble him. Yet the storyteller never makes clear whether the suspicion is true or merely a product of the protagonist's imagination. This uncertainty is itself a sign of the story's psychological realism. At its centre lies the mentality of social anxiety encapsulated in "What will people say?"—a fear that prevents the protagonist from speaking truthfully to his life partner, his doctor, and ultimately even to himself:

"He told no one. What would anyone do, even if he told them? And what could he possibly say? He had accepted his fate."

The ending is extremely brief but devastating. The doctor's final words, "Deep depression!", echo with the sound of the door closing. They name the affliction but cast no light upon what the story presents as its underlying cause: social shame and fear, and a culture in which communication has broken down. In this sense the story offers a sharp criticism of the emotional

inarticulacy embedded in masculine identity, where social expectations of "endurance" and "courage" become the greatest obstacle to acknowledging genuine suffering.

4. "Chaukparak Maugi": Urbanisation, Collective Silence, and Women's Identity

"Chaukparak Maugi" ("The Woman at the Crossroads") is a harrowing record of the dark reality of contemporary development, the erosion of language and culture, and society's extreme insensitivity towards a helpless, psychologically distressed woman. It exposes the cruel alliance between neo-capitalist development and patriarchy.

The story begins with metropolitan expansion and the creation of "Mega Chowk." Through this setting, the author reveals the cultural and social consequences of rapid urbanisation. Fields and low-lying agricultural tracts that until recently flourished with rice and wheat now bear concrete palaces, bungalows, and shopping complexes. Former cultivators have sold their land and become wealthy overnight. Their children, a new generation wearing earrings, squandering their time in ostentation, and bullying people at tea stalls, have appointed themselves guardians of social security. In reality, they exemplify nepotism and hooliganism.

The author also directs a sharp satire at the decline of language and culture. People dye their hair to look foreign, acquiring what villagers call a "bhat-ranga" appearance. By artificially inserting English and Latin terms into their speech, they betray an inferiority complex regarding their mother tongue. "Mega Chowk" is thus not merely a geographical location but a symbol of a consumerist society in which sensitivity, morality, and humanity have died. Recalling the past, the narrator speaks of the Bata company's "Ambassador Sahujī," who used to give people from Mithila shelter in his lodging when they were away from home. That age of generosity has now passed.

Amid this glitter and material progress, an unknown woman sits from morning until night upon the compound wall of an empty plot. She is exceptionally beautiful, but her clothes are dirty, her hair is matted, and a thick streak of vermilion marks the parting of her hair. This woman is the silent centre of the story. She speaks to no one. The narrator, an employee of the Forest Department, is disturbed by the sight of her. Human sympathy awakens in him and he wants to help her, but his friend Rajeshji stops him, saying that he is "getting carried away by emotion." "And what will people say if she turns out to be a woman of bad character?" This social fear forces the narrator to withdraw.

Police Sub-Inspector Ram Dayal Yadav and the local strongman, Rabi, likewise dismiss her as merely mentally disturbed or "mad," thereby evading their responsibilities. This neutrality and neglect—the bystander effect—constitute the prelude to a serious crime.

The ending is profoundly tragic and deeply unsettling. One day, some months later, a large crowd gathers at the crossroads. The woman is drenched

in sweat, tearing at her clothes and hair, and crying out in anguish. The story clearly suggests that she has suffered a collective sexual assault. Her outcry is one of the most powerful expressions of feminist discourse in Maithili literature, striking directly at the arrogance of masculinity:

"Yes, I am the woman of the crossroads!... That is all I am fit for!!... All of you, have your pleasure!... Show your strength!! Against the woman of the crossroads... who is defenceless... and has no one to protect her... use your force against her, display your manhood! Oh, God! I am now the woman of the crossroads!!"

This is not merely the delirious speech of a psychologically distressed woman. It is a resounding slap in the face of an entire supposedly civilised, newly affluent, patriarchal society—a society that makes the weak and helpless victims of its lust instead of protecting them. When a woman finds herself abandoned, distressed, or without support at a public crossroads, this so-called civilised society, rather than becoming her protector, turns her into an "object of enjoyment," the "woman of the crossroads."

The narrator is overcome by intense remorse. Unable to go to the office, he returns home and collapses upon his bed. He realises that he himself, his friend Rajesh, the police officer Yadav, and society at large are implicated in this heinous crime. The inaction into which he retreated out of the cowardly fear of "what people will say" became a fundamental cause of the tragedy.

The following table permits a comparative analysis of the social attitudes of the characters in "Chaukparak Maugi."

The third story does not begin immediately with the woman. First, it constructs the entire social geography of the crossroads. The English-sounding name "Mega Chowk," the incursion of English words into everyday language, houses, bungalows, and shopping towers rising over the green fields, sudden wealth caused by escalating land prices, the vulgar display of money by young men, markets, cosmetics shops, rock music, and electronic advertisements together compose a spectacle of development.

Georg Simmel writes of the intensity of metropolitan stimulation, money-based calculation, and the indifferent or guarded disposition developed in the interests of self-protection. The town in "Chaukparak Maugi" may not be a metropolis in the full sense, but it certainly belongs to a transitional zone of rapid urbanisation. The story captures a crucial discrepancy: material transformation proceeds swiftly, whereas the transformation of moral institutions is uneven. Bridges, roads, shops, mobile phones, police networks, and local centres of power are present, yet the enduring presence of a helpless woman never becomes a matter of public concern.

5.2 The Nameless Woman and an Identity Bestowed by the Crossroads

The title is itself an act of criticism. The woman has no name: she is "Chaukparak Maugi," the woman at the crossroads. Her identity is therefore derived not from her birth, work, wishes, past, or relationships, but from her body sitting in a public place. The everyday use of *maugi* lends the story its

local linguistic character, but the repetition of the word in the title also exposes the bitterness of her objectification. Society regards her not as a person but as a spectacle.

The narrator examines her beauty, breasts, complexion, hair, vermilion, and clothes with a detailed gaze. On one level, such description gives poignant visibility to her plight; on another, it reproduces the problem of the male gaze. The story's achievement is that its own narrator does not become an innocent moral hero. The fear that she may be a "bad woman," anxiety about what others will say, concern about his wife's reaction, and even the possibility of attraction to the woman all operate as prejudices within him. His final guilt demands that this initial gaze be reassessed.

5.3 Bystander Inaction: "Everyone Saw; No One Acted"

The narrator repeatedly considers approaching the woman. His friend Rajesh says, "There are many like her" and "Attend to your own problems first." The police sub-inspector dismisses her as mentally ill; the local strongman Rabi, having previously asked her questions and received no answer, likewise withdraws. Responsibility is continually passed from one person to another. Bibb Latané and John Darley's concepts of the "bystander effect" and "diffusion of responsibility" are especially relevant here: the larger the number of potential helpers, the less an individual may experience the obligation to help as a personal duty.

Yet the story is not confined to being an illustration of social psychology. The author adds local determinants: "what will people say," suspicion concerning a woman's character, the risk of unnecessary legal entanglements, social surveillance of relations between men and women, routine police indifference, and the limited, patriarchal justice of local power-holders. Inaction is consequently produced not merely by the size of the crowd, but also by fear for one's reputation and by gender prejudice.

5.4 The Final Cry: The Silent Woman's Explosion into Language

The woman who scarcely speaks throughout the story finally speaks in clear, intelligible language. Shouting, she calls herself "Chaukparak Maugi" and mocks the violent exhibition of manhood. The story does not provide a full factual account of the event—precisely what happened to her, who did it, or when. All this remains untold. This gap functions not so much as an unfinished mystery as a social indictment: the question is not merely the name of the perpetrator, but the entire environment in which a vulnerable, helpless, and unprotected woman remained visible to everyone.

At the end, the narrator's admission—"I am guilty"—turns the story away from moral instruction towards self-accusation. This is an important formal decision. Had the narrative ended by blaming only the police, the local thugs, or "society," the reader could have remained an outsider. Instead, the narrator includes himself among those responsible; as a result, readers must ask themselves how often they too have merely watched, worried, and talked without taking action. Martha Nussbaum connects the literary imagination

with sympathy and public justice. In this sense the story seeks to transform a reader's sympathy from a passive emotion into an active ethical question.

The collection's third and most politically and socially incisive story, "Chaukparak Maugi," begins against the background of a village undergoing urbanisation. Its traditional market junction has been renamed with a modern expression such as "Mega Chowk," and old farming families have become suddenly rich because of the rising value of their land. In portraying this changing environment, the storyteller offers subtle commentary on urbanisation's cultural costs: the Anglicisation of language, the erosion of tradition, and the dazzling display of newly acquired wealth.

At this junction, the first-person narrator sees a silent, dishevelled, yet apparently well-educated woman sitting each day. She wears vermilion in her hair, is alone and visibly distressed, and speaks to no one. The narrator feels pity for her; but just as he considers speaking to her, his friend Rajeshji warns him:

"Leave it! If some untoward matter is involved, we shall get unnecessarily entangled."

"And if she turns out to be a bad woman, what will people say?"

The refrain "what will people say," which played a central role in "Deep Depression," operates here on a much wider social plane. The narrator also asks Police Sub-Inspector Ram Dayal Yadav and the local strongman Rabi about the woman. Both institutions—the police and informal local authority —declare her "mentally ill" and wash their hands of responsibility. The storyteller thus presents a multilayered portrait of institutional indifference: family, friends, police, and the local community all find their own arguments to justify non-intervention.

At the story's climactic moment, the woman whom everyone has regarded as "mad" cries out in language that is exceptionally lucid, reasoned, and heartrending, exposing her reality:

"Yes, I am the woman of the crossroads!... Fit for nothing more!!... All of you, have your pleasure!... Show your strength!!"

"Against the woman of the crossroads... who is defenceless... and has no one to protect her..."

"Use your force against her, show your manhood!... Oh, God!... I am now the woman of the crossroads!!"

This explosive declaration makes clear, in the reading offered here, that the woman was never simply "mad": she had repeatedly been subjected to sexual exploitation, while society mistook her trauma-induced silence and unusual behaviour for madness, ignoring her actual suffering. The story concludes with a remarkably direct ethical judgement, applicable to the narrator himself and to the reader:

"I am guilty! Everyone around me is guilty!!"

This ending transforms the story from a poignant tale into a moral indictment. Readers, too, cannot wholly escape the guilt of being counted among "everyone around me."

Character	Social role and position	Attitude towards the woman
Narrator	Educated, sensitive, middle-class individual	Sympathetic but inactive through fear for his social reputation (a bystander)
Rajeshji	Narrator's friend, a realist	Detached and suspicious; sees altruism as a risk
Ram Dayal Yadav	Police sub-inspector (law and order)	Irresponsible; dismisses the woman as mad; makes only a superficial inquiry
Rabi	Local strongman at the crossroads (informal authority)	Regards the woman as unrelated to him, outside the scope of his influence
The woman at the crossroads	Helpless, psychologically distressed, and without support	Victim of society's lust and cruelty; victim of patriarchal inhumanity

5. Common Threads in the Three Stories: The Body, Silence, the Gaze, and Responsibility

In all three stories, the body is a primary site of narrative meaning. In "Golba," the body is first kissed, caressed, adorned, and fed; ultimately, that very body becomes something to be slaughtered, skinned, and cooked. In "Deep Depression," the mind's unspoken suffering is inscribed upon the body through the chest, pulse, perspiration, breathing, blood pressure, and numbness. In "Chaukparak Maugi," the woman's body becomes the centre of the social gaze, descriptions of beauty, vulnerability, and potential violence.

This sequence may be called a trilogy of "control over the body." Golba's body belongs, in the family's eyes, to the family; the depressed character wishes to exercise control over his own body, but the fears of the mind take possession of it; and the social gaze and masculine power assert an aggressive right over the woman's body at the crossroads. The collection thus arrives at a universal question: to whom does a living body belong? Love, family, tradition, marriage, society, the state, the police, and the market all lay claim to the body. Where, then, does the autonomy of the person—or the living creature—reside?

7. Silence, Language, and Truth

Another significant dimension of the collection is the conflict between language and silence. "Golba" cannot speak a human language, and so his

dissent is continually translated according to human convenience. The protagonist of "Deep Depression," although possessed of language, does not tell the truth: words are available, but courage and evidence are lacking. The woman at the crossroads is excluded from social dialogue; her final scream establishes that the problem was not an inability to speak, but society's unwillingness to hear her voice.

Seen in this light, the three stories examine the "ethics of narration." Which suffering is to be told, and by whom? Whose words are considered credible? When the sufferer does not speak, does the witness's responsibility end—or become greater? Again and again the storyteller offers readers incomplete clues without granting them the convenience of conclusive proof. This may be understood as a modern narrative form of the theory of *dhvani*, or suggestion: the principal meaning often resides precisely where the story does not speak explicitly.

(a) The Exploitation of the Defenceless

The central figures of the three stories—Golba (the goat), the man suffering from depression, and the woman at the crossroads—are, in different ways, either "voiceless" or "unheard." Golba does not possess human language; the depressed man refuses to speak his truth because of social shame; and the woman's truthful speech is dismissed as "madness" and ignored. In all three situations, although the sufferer has a private "voice," society either fails to hear it or hears it and deliberately turns away.

(b) "What Will People Say?": The Logic of Social Silence

In both "Deep Depression" and "Chaukparak Maugi," fear of "what people will say" repeatedly prevents characters from acting rightly. This social-psychological motif constitutes a conscious critical observation by the storyteller: a culture of fear-driven propriety in which protecting "honour" and "reputation" takes precedence over genuine compassion and justice.

(c) The Skilful Use of Dramatic Irony

The storyteller employs irony differently in each of the three stories. In "Golba," the difference between what the reader knows and what the character knows intensifies the tragedy. In "Deep Depression," readers gradually realise that the character's very insistence upon being "normal" is itself symptomatic of his illness. In "Chaukparak Maugi," the woman regarded as "mad" ultimately proves to be the most clear-sighted and outspoken person of all. These three distinct uses of irony demonstrate the storyteller's profound command of narrative technique.

The deepest unity of the collection lies not in its subject matter but in its ethical structure: a living creature or human being suffers; many signs are present; witnesses are there; yet language, fear, tradition, suspicion, or social indifference prevents help. This structure makes 'Golba' not merely a short-story collection but a 'trilogy of responsibility'.

6. Narrative Technique, Imagery, and Linguistic Style

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's literary technique displays mature seriousness and a multidimensional perspective. He is accomplished in selecting narrative techniques appropriate to his subject matter, a skill that gives his works a distinctive place in contemporary literature.

In "Golba," the author adopts an anthropomorphic perspective: the narrative unfolds through an animal's sensory experience and, at the end, merges into a vision of disembodied existence. This method presents reality from a different, penetrating angle, in which human cruelty is perceived through the eyes of an innocent animal.

"Deep Depression" makes excellent use of stream of consciousness and interior monologue. No major external event takes place within the story, yet the suspicions and tensions of the protagonist's subconscious mind revolve like a reel of film, allowing readers to experience mental suffocation almost directly.

In "Chaukparak Maugi," a documentary mode of social realism is combined with a first-person confessional narrative that profoundly unsettles the reader. Like a camera, the narrator records the transformation of the crossroads, the attitudes of its people, and the ultimate tragedy.

In matters of language and imagery, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's writing is enriched by the flavour, proverbs, and idioms of idiomatic Maithili. His language carries the earthy fragrance of Mithila's soil, together with biting satire capable of expressing modern anguish. Local Maithili expressions such as "kahan don" (the heel), "chabhaki-chabhaki ka," "oriaon," "koriaïni," "bhataranga," "chokatal munh-kan," "gheona pasarae," and "bhathi jakan" lend the stories exceptional vitality and authenticity.

Imagery is the very lifeblood of these stories. In "Golba," the blood-red sword, the convulsing torso, and the soul soaring into space create a striking contrast between cruelty and detachment. In "Deep Depression," the shuttered room with its closed window and curtains, and the "smell of Tulsi-brand chewing tobacco," form an intense image of psychological triggers that drive the protagonist towards mental disarray. In "Chaukparak Maugi," the concrete mansions stand beside a woman in soiled clothes, with a thick streak of vermilion, sitting upon a compound wall: a forceful image of material development set against human decline, embodying society's contradictions.

Genette's concept of focalisation is especially useful in understanding the collection's craft. In "Golba," internal focalisation becomes an unusual vehicle for animal experience. In "Deep Depression," third-person narration approaches free indirect style: the boundary between the narrator's voice and the character's thoughts repeatedly becomes blurred. In "Chaukparak Maugi," the first-person narrator is simultaneously witness, interpreter, and moral defendant.

The handling of time also differs. “Golba” follows a comparatively linear movement from birth to slaughter. “Deep Depression” inhabits a circular temporality rooted in memory: a small stimulus in the present reactivates suspicions from the past. “Chaukparak Maugi” establishes both the woman’s continued presence and society’s inaction through repeated daily routines—seeing her on the way to the office and again on the return journey—until the final day breaks that routine.

Rita Felski emphasises four uses of literature: recognition, enchantment, knowledge, and shock. “Golba” offers recognition through affection for the animal and shock at the end; “Deep Depression” provides knowledge and recognition of the instability of the mind; and “Chaukparak Maugi” combines an understanding of social inaction with the shock of self-recognition. The collection’s effect, from this perspective, is not simply that “the stories were enjoyable”: it is self-examination.

10. Language and Style

10.1 Colloquial Maithili and Local Sensibility

The collection’s language is essentially grounded in spoken Maithili. In “Golba,” domestic words—Barki Mai, Soni-Moni, Babbu, grass and fodder, *dubi* grass, bedding, tassels, the pond, and the household shrine—give the story a cultural body. In “Deep Depression,” the doctor’s conversations, the protagonist’s internal dialogue, and domestic suspicions together produce a mixed psychological register. In “Chaukparak Maugi,” vocabulary associated with the crossroads, market, police, local strongmen, mobile phones, shopping, and contemporary consumer culture produces a change of register.

The advantage of this plurality of registers is that the three stories are not forced into the same linguistic mould. The sensibility of village households, the medical vocabulary of the educated middle class, and the hybrid speech of the newly urbanised marketplace create distinct social worlds. In “Chaukparak Maugi” in particular, the narrator himself satirises the influence of English; when the story subsequently presents a world of “shopping,” “cosmetics,” “stylish,” “rock,” “electronic,” and similar words, linguistic mixture becomes a subject in its own right.

10.2 Satire, Exclamations, and Self-Expression

The author makes extensive use of exclamation marks, questions, self-directed speech, local idioms, and narratorial comments. These give the language vitality and a speaking presence; at certain points, however, excessive exclamation risks pressing an emotion too insistently upon the reader. Particularly when the event is already sufficiently intense, stylistic restraint could heighten its impact.

Satire is especially successful in the third story. The name “Mega Chowk,” the attraction of foreignness, sudden wealth derived from land, nouveau-riche manners, local bullying, and the glitter of the “modern” market—all these invite commentary from the narrator that is not merely humorous but critical of the uneven moral consequences of development.

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's prose style achieves a remarkable balance between descriptive expansiveness and psychological subtlety. In "Golba," the fine details of rural family life—food, games, festivals, and celebrations—construct a rich cultural background, making the final tragedy all the more powerful. In "Deep Depression," interior monologue takes readers directly into the character's mental turmoil; the frequent interrogative sentences ("Then how could he possibly have depression?"; "Is this diagnosis not correct?") bring his self-doubt and self-deception to life. In "Chaukparak Maugi," a dialogue-driven manner—conversations with Rajeshji, the police, and the local strongman—gives the narrative the character of a social investigation that moves gradually towards the revelation of truth.

At the linguistic level, all three stories naturally employ idioms and proverbs from idiomatic Maithili, establishing them upon an authentic cultural foundation. The dialogue is realistic and appropriate to the individual characters. The woman's final explosive speech in "Chaukparak Maugi" is particularly charged with dramatic intensity and deeply stirs the reader.

7. In the Light of Indian Poetics and Modern Narrative Theory

The stories reveal a remarkable development of the various *rasas* recognised in Indian poetics. In Golba's childhood, the maternal tenderness of Barki Mai and the affectionate attention of Soni and Moni give expression to *vatsalya rasa*, the sentiment of parental love. Golba's sacrifice and the final cry of the woman in "Chaukparak Maugi" bring *karuna* (pathos) and *bhayanaka* (terror) to their fullest intensity. The severing of the tongue after decapitation, the convulsions of the headless body, and the suggestion of bestial sexual violence against the woman at the crossroads evoke *bibhatsa* (revulsion) and *raudra* (fury). Finally, Golba's soul ascending into space in a state of detachment signifies *shanta rasa*, the sentiment of tranquillity, and philosophical transcendence.

A mechanical application of Bharata Muni's theory of *rasa* to modern fiction would be inappropriate, yet a *rasa*-based perspective remains useful in analysing emotional structure. Compassion is central to all three stories. The killing of a helpless creature in "Golba," the mind disintegrating under self-doubt in "Deep Depression," and public neglect and violence in "Chaukparak Maugi" elicit grief, pity, and moral unease in readers. But this is not mere sentimentality. In each story, compassion is mingled with feelings of terror, disgust, rage, or tranquillity.

At the end of "Golba," the narrative moves from the terrifying and the repellent towards a tranquil or transcendent tone. In "Deep Depression," fear and compassion merge: the character is afraid not of an external enemy but of a possible truth. The woman's final cry in "Chaukparak Maugi" transforms compassion into fury; for a moment, the silent victim becomes the accuser. Because of these shifts in *rasa*, the collection does not become a monotonous sequence of pathetic tales.

8.2 Dhvani and Unspoken Meaning

According to Anandavardhana's theory of *dhvani*, significant literary meaning often emerges beyond what is directly stated. The collection contains three principal fields of suggestion. First, bringing Golba up with extraordinary affection may, in the end, also constitute preparation for his sacrifice; the story does not announce this at its beginning. Second, the author gives no decisive answer to whether the suspicion in "Deep Depression" is true. The story therefore remains centred not upon jealousy or adultery as established facts but upon the experience of suspicion. Third, the complete history of the woman at the crossroads is absent. Her silence and final eruption into language demand of the reader the ethical labour of filling in the gaps.

8.3 The Question of Aucitya, or Appropriateness

If we take *aucitya* in the broad sense of appropriateness associated here with Mammata, the proportion of every episode to its subject, character, and emotional effect becomes important. The tenderness lavished upon Golba at the beginning gives the violence at the end its necessary depth; the detailed treatment is therefore appropriate. The lengthy description of the social transformation of the crossroads in "Chaukparak Maugi" likewise provides the groundwork for understanding the indifferent society of the ending, although editorial tightening might have condensed certain passages. In "Deep Depression," Guruji's philosophical discourse forms part of the story's atmosphere but sometimes overwhelms its psychological immediacy.

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8. The Cover as Paratext

The book's cover prominently displays the sky and clouds, a landscape, and, in the foreground, the figure of a goat or another animal. The title "Golba" and the designation "short-story collection" are clearly printed. The cover visually places the first and title story at the centre of the collection. From a paratextual perspective, it leads the reader to expect an animal story, whereas the other two stories in the collection deal with psychological and urban-social themes. This disparity establishes the symbolic precedence of the title story on the one hand; on the other, the full thematic range of the collection cannot immediately be inferred from its cover.

9. Literary Achievements and Limitations

Credible and compassionate focalisation of animal experience: "Golba" takes readers beyond an anthropocentric perspective governed by human convenience.

The formal representation of psychological repetition: in "Deep Depression," a cycle of thoughts becomes the very form of the narrative.

The social geography of rapid urbanisation: "Chaukparak Maugi" brings land, markets, language, the police, local power, and women's safety into a single narrative field.

Moral uncertainty: the author leaves several decisive facts unexplained, compelling readers to accept the risk of judgement.

The multilayered nature of silence: animal voicelessness, human self-concealment, and a woman's social unheardness bind the three stories together.

The recurring symbolism of the body: a body nurtured and then cut apart, a body trembling with anxiety, and a woman's body subjected to public scrutiny and violence—these constitute the collection's deepest thematic unity.

The memorability of the endings: each story ultimately changes how readers interpret what came before—sacrifice, diagnosis, and the cry of pain and guilt.

13. Critical Limitations and Possibilities for Improvement

Certain limitations of the collection do not diminish its importance; rather, they indicate further possibilities for the development of its craft.

At some points, narratorial explanation begins to speak more loudly than the scenes themselves. Especially in the posthumous philosophical reflections of "Golba" and the Guruji episode of "Deep Depression," greater concision might have strengthened the suggestive power of the narrative.

The title "Deep Depression" conveys the certainty of a clinical term, whereas the experience represented in the story combines anxiety, fear, suspicion, repetitive thoughts, and physical panic. Literary ambiguity is a

strength, but the diagnostic rigidity of the title channels the reader's response in one particular direction.

In "Chaukparak Maugi," the opening description of the woman's physical beauty is prolonged. If the author intends to criticise the male gaze, the narrator's self-accusation at the end invites us to reread that description. Nevertheless, some readers may find that it also reproduces the very objectification it seeks to condemn.

The description of the town in the third story is exceptionally rich, although selective cutting could have given the story a tighter structure. Yet the expansiveness serves a purpose: the final event appears not as a "sudden crime" but as the consequence of an entire social environment.

The abundance of punctuation marks and exclamation marks sometimes makes emotional cues clearer but can also reduce subtlety.

The female characters have limited access to a voice of their own in all three stories. In the third story, this becomes a deliberate theme of silence; nevertheless, granting an abused woman an interior perspective could be an important expansion of the narrative world in future writing.

• Thematic courage: the three stories take up subjects rarely addressed in Maithili short fiction—the ethics of animal sacrifice, men's mental health, and society's refusal to acknowledge sexual violence. This choice of subjects is itself an act of literary courage.

• Diversity of perspective: animal consciousness ("Golba"), a man's internal conflict ("Deep Depression"), and social investigation ("Chaukparak Maugi") employ three distinct narrative angles, giving the collection formal variety.

• Moral clarity without didacticism: all three stories raise profound ethical questions in the reader's mind without delivering direct sermons. The narrative structures and their ironies perform that work in themselves—a mark of mature storytelling.

Limitations

• In "Deep Depression," the allegation of the wife's supposed infidelity is neither directly confirmed nor disproved. Although this appears to be a deliberate ambiguity—the story's principal concern is the man's psychological condition rather than the wife's guilt or innocence—it nonetheless leaves the wife herself as a voiceless object of suspicion. This may seem somewhat contradictory to the story's own central concern with the critique of voicelessness.

• The opening portion of "Golba" is considerably more expansive than the intensely described scenes of sacrifice and death at its end. Some readers may therefore find the pacing uneven, although that long opening may itself be a deliberate strategy for deepening the emotional investment that makes the tragedy effective.

10. Significance in the Context of Contemporary Maithili Fiction

The collection's importance may be argued on the basis not of its representation of history as a whole but of its distinctive narrative daring. It introduces into fiction three subjects—domestic animals, mental health, and women's safety in public spaces—whose ethical significance is often concealed by conventional social language. Rather than offer readers an immediate reformist lecture, it first induces affection, anxiety, observation, and uncertainty, and only then leaves them with guilt or an unresolved question.

One of the great strengths of Maithili fiction has always been its fine-grained attention to local life. In this collection, locality is not simply a setting; it is a medium of thought. Barki Mai's sari, the chill of the pond, the household shrine, the doctor's clinic, the smell of Tulsi-brand chewing tobacco, the newly built crossroads, roasted maize, the local strongman, and the police outpost give the narratives palpable life. Modern questions arise not from borrowed terminology but from local experience.

11. Conclusion

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's literary thought embodies a democratic consciousness capable of taking into itself the suffering of the person—or animal—at the very margins of society. While his political life has been directly dedicated to democratic reform in structures of power and governance, his literary writing advocates social and psychological democracy. Whereas the Nepali novels "Sumnima" and "Modiain," translated into Maithili by him, explore human nature through historical and mythological narratives, his original short-story collection "Golba" stands firmly upon the ground of contemporary reality.

Viewed as a whole, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's "Golba" is a highly significant, intellectually forceful, and enduring achievement of modern Maithili prose. The book is not merely an instrument of entertainment; it is a psychological and sociological document that shakes the reader's sensibilities and compels introspection.

Where "Golba" launches a severe attack upon human selfishness, counterfeit affection, and inhuman violence committed in the name of religion, "Deep Depression" gives voice to the depression, marital emptiness, and suffocating male psychology that spread through the dark recesses of modern life. "Chaukparak Maugi" unmasks the inhuman face of our supposedly civilised, urbanised, and modern society, in which human sensitivity has been crushed beneath piles of concrete and the identity and dignity of a helpless woman are falling prey to masculine arrogance.

His stories offer neither idealistic solutions nor sermons. Instead, they perform a kind of realistic surgery, laying society's wounds bare before readers and compelling them to think for themselves. This manner of writing places him alongside the great practitioners of psychological realism in world

literature. For the rare synthesis of linguistic lucidity, subtle psychological analysis, existential philosophy, and social realism found in these stories, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's book will always be remembered with high regard in the history of Maithili literature. "Golba" possesses every qualification to establish itself as an indispensable and important reference work for students of the fragmentation of contemporary society, feminist discourse, the tragedy of neoliberal urbanisation, and modern psychology.

After reading the three stories of "Golba," the most lasting impression is that suffering often takes place before everyone's eyes, yet understanding its significance and becoming answerable to it are difficult matters. Golba was loved, but he had no control over his own life. The protagonist of "Deep Depression" has a family and a doctor at hand, yet the decisive truth remains unspoken. The woman at the crossroads is visible to everyone every day, yet her circumstances repeatedly fall through the gap between private and social responsibility.

The collection unfolds this moral paradox on three levels: love does not always prevent violence; knowledge, in the absence of evidence, can become paralysis; and compassion, without action, can become self-satisfaction. Thus, "Golba" is not merely a set of three sorrowful stories but a test of compassion itself. Readers are asked: when we love someone, do we recognise that person's freedom, or merely turn them into the object of our affection? When we are burdened by suspicion or pain, how much moral courage do we possess to tell the truth? And when we witness another person's suffering, how long do we remain silent out of fear of "what people will say"?

Artistically, the collection's finest moments are those in which the author declines to provide an answer: the question of Golba's ultimate existence, the uncertain truth behind the suspicions in "Deep Depression," and the untold life history of the woman at the crossroads. In these gaps, the reader's judgement becomes active. With less explanation and more silence at certain points, the collection might have acquired still greater sharpness; even in its present form, however, it offers a remarkable conjunction of sensibility, psychology, and social ethics.

"Golba" is a noteworthy contribution to Maithili fiction, returning, from three distinct narrative angles, to the same fundamental ethical question: what duty does society owe to a helpless, voiceless creature or person, and how culpable is the "silent spectator" who fails to fulfil that duty? From the treacherous sacrifice of the trusting goat Golba, through the depression-stricken man's silence born of social shame, to the unheard cry of the woman at the crossroads, all three stories disclose a common truth: the exploitation of the defenceless becomes possible when those nearby choose to remain silent.

The direct and slogan-like voice of social justice found in Vrishesh Chandra Lal's poetry—for example, in "Dholak" and "Andolan"—assumes a subtler, more structural form in "Golba." Here moral outrage is expressed not through explicit proclamation but through narrative technique and irony. In this respect, "Golba" reveals a more mature and more multidimensional aspect of

the storyteller's literary personality, in which political and social commitment and the subtleties of narrative art complement one another effectively.

12. Principal Critical Observations by Story

Story	Principal experience	Main narrative technique	Ethical question
Golba	Affection, fear, sacrifice, death	Animal-centred internal perspective; final shock	If love fails to recognise autonomy, can it prevent violence?
Deep Depression	Suspicion, panic, silence, self-surveillance	Free indirect narration; repetitive thoughts; memory triggered by clues	When proof of the truth is absent, how can one balance the claims of the mind, the family, and justice?
Chaukparak Maugi	Urbanisation, indifference, women's vulnerability, guilt	First person; social geography; daily repetition; final cry	When will a witness to suffering accept the responsibility to become a helper?

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4. Malho

Feminist Criticism • Dalit and Subaltern Perspectives • Political and Ethical Reading • Memory Studies • Narratological Analysis

1. Introduction: Central Argument and Literary Significance

To regard *Malho* simply as a collection of nine stories about social reality would be to miss a substantial part of its literary meaning. The collection constructs an interconnected world of rural memory, women's silent suffering, caste humiliation, democratic struggle, political defection, state violence, war, love, motherhood, education, history and public morality. In this world, power is present in almost every form: the power of a husband's word within the household, caste power, police power, party power, state power, the power of tradition and the power of the male gaze. Confronting all these forms, the author repeatedly poses the same question: where does human dignity reside, and who will defend it?

The collection is distinguished by the fact that its author does not merely articulate theoretical slogans. His stories reveal the effects of social structures through his characters' bodies, waiting, shame, hunger, humiliation, tears, memories and small domestic acts. Depurwali Kaki's lifelong waiting, Malho's water lily, the humiliation suffered at school by the child of Sikandar Dom, Phuliya's red wedding sari and Indrakumari's one-tusked elephant and nine-lakh necklace cease to be ordinary objects. They become symbols of human identity and historical violence.

Continuing the tradition of accomplished storytellers such as Phanishwarnath Renu, Rajkamal Chaudhary, Lily Ray and Gangesh Gunjan, Lal presents the soil, struggles and political consciousness of Mithila–Madhesh in a realist manner. At a time when romanticism and abstraction had gained influence in modern literature, *Malho* exposes society's uncomfortable truths on the hard ground of realism.

A further critical perspective observes that, amid the influence of English and other Western languages, Lal's idiomatic, lucid Maithili gives the language renewed energy. At the same time, the collection's actual linguistic texture also accommodates the multilingual life of a border region.

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's short-story collection *Malho* represents that stream of Maithili fiction which expresses the sociopolitical reality of Nepal's Madhesh–Terai region through the Maithili language. In subject matter, these nine stories have an exceptionally broad range. On one side are the intimate family relationships of village courtyards and verandas and the tender memory of childhood love; on the other are the Panchayat system, the movement for democracy, party-switching, caste discrimination, Naxalite/People's War violence and even historical narratives of the Sen dynasty. In this respect, the collection becomes not merely a book of short

stories but also a literary document of the Madhesh in Nepal during the social and political transitions of the past fifty or sixty years—from Rana and Panchayat rule to democracy, from democracy to the people's movement, and from that movement to armed conflict.

The choice of the title story, "Malho," is itself meaningful. Malho is the name of an ordinary rural girl from a marginalised social group. She becomes a symbol of the unforced love of childhood and remains permanently inscribed in the storyteller's memory. To make her name the title signals the sensibility that runs throughout the collection: placing at its centre the inner worlds of ordinary, neglected and marginalised men and women.

Malho is a collection of short stories published by Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham.

> *The central argument of the collection can be stated in one sentence: when a person crushes another human being's dignity in the name of tradition, caste, party, state or masculine pride, the true assessment of history begins with the experience of the person who has suffered.*

2. The Writer's Ideological Grounding, Literary Journey and Narrative Milieu

Every writer's work inevitably reflects something of the struggles of their personal life and the foundations of their thinking. Vrishesh Chandra Lal was born on 29 March 1955. His father was the late Udit Narayan Lal and his mother was Mrs Bhuvaneshwari Devi. His childhood naming-ceremony name was Vishweshwar. His family and ideological background has been closely associated with Nepal's democratic movement, B. P. Koirala's (Vishweshwar Prasad Koirala's) democratic socialism, the anti-Panchayat people's movement in Nepal and the movement for self-respect in Madhesh. He is a senior politician, a former National Assembly member and an active participant in Nepal's democratic struggle, known for the clarity of his political convictions. In national politics, he has been associated with the Terai-Madhesh Loktantrik Party (TMLP) and the Janata Samajbadi Party (JSP).

His literary contribution is not confined to fiction. His Maithili adaptations of B. P. Koirala's *Modiain* and *Sumnima*, his original poetry collection *Andolan*, his collection of children's poems *Dholak*, and his short-story collections *Malho* and *Golba* together testify to his multifaceted literary personality.

Title of Work	Genre	Language	Publication / Relevant Details
Malho	Short-story collection	Maithili	Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham
Andolan	Poetry collection	Maithili	Videha e-Journal / independent publication
Dholak	Collection of	Maithili	Videha e-

Title of Work	Genre	Language	Publication / Relevant Details
	children's poems		Journal archive
Modiain	Translated novel	Maithili	Adaptation of B. P. Koirala's work
Sumnima	Translated novel	Maithili	Adaptation of B. P. Koirala's work
Towards Federal Governance (Sanghiya Shasantir)	Political / ideological work	Nepali	Based on Nepal's political transformation

Vrishesh Chandra Lal has also served as mayor of Janakpur and has been a significant figure in Madhesh-based political leadership. This background lends experiential credibility to the political worlds of "Balidani," "Patharsanak Lok ...!" and "Dhahlel Dalbadalu!" Yet biography may provide a key to a story's subject without making the story a mere copy of the author's life.

These varied experiences—from poetry to fiction, children's literature to translation, and politics to literature—also become visible in the collection's artistic procedures. The political stories draw upon speeches, recollection and interior dialogue; "Malho" and "Depurwali Kaki," by contrast, disclose their meanings through subtle indications, bodily expression, domestic memory and silence.

The author's experience centred on Janakpur and Madhesh lends particular importance to the collection's sense of place. Nepal's people's movement of 2046 B.S., the Panchayat system, party opportunism after the return of democracy, rural Madheshi society, caste structure, comparisons with India across the border, state repression and the shadow of the Maoist "People's War" are not merely historical settings. They decisively shape the characters' moral choices.

Lal keeps the realities he has directly experienced—imprisonment and torture, underground political movements, the hypocrisy of the hunger for power and the struggles of marginalised lives in the rural Terai–Madhesh—at a distance from fanciful romanticism. His fictional geography extends from the lanes of Janakpurdham and Mithila's open fields to the dark prison cells of Sindhuli and Jaleshwar, the corridors of power in Kathmandu and international conferences.

3. Structure of the Collection and Its Thematic Progression

The sequence is meaningful in itself. The opening story, "Depurwali Kaki," enters through personal memory and domestic injustice. The political stories in the middle carry individual experience onto the larger terrain of state, party

and democracy. “Sikandar Dom” and “And She Was Killed!” bring voices from society's margins to the centre. The final story reconstructs an episode of history within contemporary feminist consciousness. Thus the collection expands from the veranda of a home to the state, war and history, yet everywhere the human being remains its fundamental unit.

The collection contains nine stories: “Depurabali Kaki,” “Balidani Balidani,” “Patharsanak Lok,” “Malho,” “Dhahlel Dalbadalu,” “Kari Kobham,” “Sikandar Dom,” “And She Was Killed!” and “The One-Tusked Elephant and the Nine-Lakh Necklace.” A close examination of this order suggests that the author has deliberately constructed a circular arrangement. At both the beginning and the end, a woman's sacrifice and silent struggle are central (Depurabali Kaki and Indrakumari); in the intervening portion lies a trio of political and social stories; and near the middle the title story “Malho” stands as a tender personal memory. This structural balance makes the book appear not merely an assemblage of scattered tales but a carefully conceived thematic journey.

No.	Story	Pages	Principal Subject
1	Depurwali Kaki	2–8	Memory, patriarchy, marital injustice, waiting
2	Balidani	9–12	Democracy, martyrdom, political memory
3	Patharsanak Lok ...!	13–16	Police violence, politics, intergenerational fear
4	Malho	17–24	Love, class distance, women’s dignity, motherhood
5	Dhahlel Dalbadalu!	25–31	Party-switching, patronage, democracy
6	Kari Kobham	32–34	Bodily gaze, age, marriage, motherhood
7	Sikandar Dom	35–37	Caste, untouchability, education
8	And She Was Killed!	38–42	War, love, state violence, media
9	The One-	43–45	History, dowry,

No.	Story	Pages	Principal Subject
	Tusked Elephant and the Nine-Lakh Necklace		women's identity, public patrimony

4. Close Readings of the Individual Stories

4.1 "Depurwali Kaki": The Long Shadow of Patriarchy across the Screen of Memory

The first story opens with an emphatically modern scene: television, the film *Teesri Kasam*, Waheeda Rehman's image, a computer and photographic manipulation. This world of modern technology suddenly carries the narrator to the face of a woman from his village past. Through this formal device the author demonstrates that memory is not linear: an image, a smell, a voice or the resemblance of a face can break through the screen of the present and bring the past vividly to life.

Depurwali Kaki is the woman who offered the narrator affection, care and protection during his childhood. Her beauty is mentioned, but the story gradually moves away from outward beauty and enters the suffering of her unspoken life. As the stories of Misri Kaka, Rigawali and child marriage unfold, it becomes evident that Kaki's tragedy is not the result of some divinely ordained "sin from a previous birth." It is the product of masculine pride, a misplaced vow and the family's and society's silent acquiescence. This is a significant ethical reversal: the story first offers the folk explanation of "fate," then contests it through the voices of women in the household.

Madhu's anger performs the work of criticism within the narrative. She attacks the male disposition by which one woman is subjected to lifelong injustice on account of another, and a man's "vow" becomes the measure of his morality while a woman pays its price. "Depurwali Kaki" is therefore not simply a sorrowful story; it re-examines the moral vocabulary of patriarchy—dharma, the keeping of one's word, endurance and fidelity to one's husband.

The story's culminating irony is exceptionally powerful. Overcome by remorse, Misri Kaka vows never again to leave the household. Kaki, having at last received the moment for which she has waited, shares her almost uncontainable happiness with the entire village. Yet she dies that very night. Time grants only a few hours to a reunion awaited for a lifetime. The episode exposes the ethical futility of patriarchy's belated repentance: forgiveness may be necessary, but it cannot restore the years that have been destroyed.

An Achievement of Narrative Form

Beginning with a photograph that awakens memory, descending into an orally transmitted family narrative and childhood recollection, and then returning to an emotional response in the present, this multilayered narration raises the story above the level of an ordinary family reminiscence. Kaki's silence, the courtyard and veranda, food, fanning someone, waiting at the

door—such small domestic images write a larger history of women's invisible labour and oppression.

When talk spreads of Misri Kaka's association with another woman named Rigawali, conflict breaks out in the family. Rather than correct his own mistake, he takes a vow never to speak to Depurwali Kaki or sleep in their home for the rest of his life; Ramnan's veranda becomes his permanent place of rest.

Without complaint, Kaki continues washing her husband's clothes, preparing his food and looking after him. Much later Misri Kaka sobs aloud and asks for forgiveness. Overjoyed at the reunion she has awaited so long, Kaki shares her happiness throughout the village, but dies of a heart attack that very night. Two months later Misri Kaka too dies, consumed by the fires of remorse.

The image of "a ruinous vow like Bhishma's" lays bare the pointless rigidity of male pride. Set against Waheeda Rehman's external, cinematic beauty, Depurwali Kaki's inward and tragic beauty gives the story a different gravity.

At the end of the story, the portrayal of Kaki's name and identity being forgotten after only two generations—"Which Depurabali Kaki?"—makes the cruelty of time even more acute.

4.2 "Balidani" ("Those Who Sacrificed"): Who Owns the Memory of Martyrdom?

"Balidani" is a story about politics appropriating the memory of a movement after democracy has been attained. The observance of time at public events, behaviour on the platform, the display involved in organising a programme and the presence of self-appointed heroes of the movement enable the author, from the outset, to draw a finely satirical portrait of public political culture. The people's movement of 2046 B.S. gives the story a specific historical ground, but its question is broader: who acquires the right to the memory of a revolution after it succeeds?

The central figure represents a generation that endured repression, prison, injuries and personal loss, only to find itself pushed to the margins of the political order after democracy returned. Opportunists, caste-based factions and even criminals enter the processes by which victims are assisted, political prisoners listed, recommendations secured and honours awarded. At this point, the story reveals the politics of institutional memory: whoever controls the records also controls history.

The story nevertheless refuses to end in pessimism. Its protagonist is distressed by the distortions of present-day democracy, yet his memory of Panchayat repression prompts him to resist regression. The writer does not deify democracy: he reveals corruption and the theft of memory within it, while acknowledging the ethical value of a democratic sphere that can be reformed, as compared with dictatorship. This political maturity saves the story from becoming partisan propaganda.

> *The story's most original intervention is its recognition that the martyr's widow and children are also 'those who sacrificed,' because they have lost the golden years of life, affection, security and companionship. 'Balidani,' pp. 9–12*

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With this redefinition, martyrdom ceases to be the solitary heroic narrative of a man. The long-lasting suffering of his family, particularly women and children, comes to the centre of political remembrance. Garland ceremonies and slogans on a public platform last only a moment, but a widow's solitary life is an enduring sacrifice. The story reveals the invisible domestic cost of the nationalist heroic narrative.

The memorial meeting in the story is associated with the martyrdom of Durganand Jha, who was executed after a bomb attack on King Mahendra at Janakpur during the Panchayat era. The term *chaite* becomes a satirical designation for opportunists who abruptly turned into revolutionaries after the arrival of democracy and began collecting party positions and benefits.

On the platform, a story is being told about the martyr's reading of the Gita and the Ramayana in his final hours. But in the central character's mind a question arises: are the true "sacrificers" not, even more than the martyr himself, his young widowed wife, his aged mother and his family, who have spent an entire lifetime wasting away amid tears, deprivation and terror?

Although the story expresses disillusionment with the distortions of democracy, it does not support a return to authoritarian rule. The sentiment that "even a foolish democracy is a thousand times better than the Panchayat system" makes the freedom to resist the fundamental ethical test.

4.3 "Patharsanak Lok ...!" ("People Like Stone ...!"): Moral Courage, Idealism and Parental Fear

This is a moving account of how politics re-enters a household that wishes to distance itself from it. The father has himself endured the suffering of earlier political struggles. His wife Madhu wants to protect the family from politics. Yet their son rushes to rescue a schoolboy being beaten by the police and is himself struck with batons. The question is no longer who decided to "enter politics." It becomes this: when injustice unfolds before one's eyes, is remaining silent not itself a political act?

The father's inner conflict is the life of the story. On the one hand, he is proud of his son's courage; on the other, his own experience makes him advise the boy to stay away from politics. The author captures in this contradiction the historical exhaustion of an entire generation. Those who suffered imprisonment and beatings for their ideals have subsequently witnessed opportunism, casteism and the power of wealth under democracy. They wish to shield their children from that cycle, yet they have also passed on precisely the moral sensitivity that compels their children to intervene whenever they see injustice.

The title "Patharsanak Lok ...!" signifies not merely the hardness of the police or the state, but also poses a question about society's loss of feeling. Onlookers can stand still while a child is beaten; the system commits violence in the name of "rules"; political parties turn suffering into opportunity. In such a world, to call the young man who runs to save the victim reckless is itself an indication of a heart turned to stone.

Madhu makes a stern reckoning of the price her husband's devotion to politics has imposed on the family. Politics, she says, is either for the wealthy, "like Shumsher," or for mendicants, "like Bhattarai." Seeing her husband in her son, she calls such people "like stone"—selfless individuals whose sacrifices society often dismisses and ridicules as "foolishness."

4.4 "Malho": The Water Lily, Unequal Love, Class Distance and a Woman's Dignity

The title story, "Malho," is the collection's aesthetic centre. At its opening, the narrator returns to his village and finds his mother waiting at the *durkha*, near the entrance. The sight transports him to his elder sister, the old village, bicycles, unpaved roads, a radio given as dowry, fields and the world of childhood. The passage of time—from rough roads to motor vehicles—is not merely a change of scenery within the story; it measures the widening of memory and social distance. The narrator is now a man of status, surrounded by urban prestige and administrative and public recognition, while Malho has remained on the hard ground of her struggle.

The author constructs the relationship between the young Malho and the narrator not through declarations of love, but through water lilies, sidelong glances, bashful smiles and small incidents near fields and ponds. Malho steps into the water, plucks a water lily and says, "This is for you." At their last meeting before her marriage, she gives him another flower and speaks of observing the duties prescribed by society. The water lily is more than an emblem of love: it is a beauty blooming amid mud and water, difficult to reach and transitory once plucked.

Twenty or twenty-five years later, the story brings the moral debt of the past into the present in the person of Malho's son, Sundar Sahni. He has passed his School Leaving Certificate examination. The narrator advises him to continue his studies, but Malho's simple question—"And who will pay for his further education?"—instantly turns his confidence into discomfort. That night he fears that Malho might ask for something that could compromise his reputation, his social position or his public image as an administrator. Here the writer subtly uncovers the class-bound instinct of self-protection in the male mind.

Malho, however, demands neither money nor a job nor any personal claim upon him. Abandoned or turned out by her husband, she has supported and educated her son through her own labour. In the end, her request concerns only the boy's education. At this moment Malho's moral stature appears greater than the narrator's social stature. She does not ask to be compensated

for their former love, nor does she beg for pity. She asks for an opportunity for the future: that her son may study.

The final scene returns to the water lily. Malho gives the narrator a flower and walks away; "This is for you" continues to reverberate in his ears. This circular structure binds the story's past and present within a single symbol. The flower signifies at once love, forgiveness, distance, memory and an impossible union. The achievement of "Malho" is that it does not turn the incompleteness of love into sentimental lamentation. It locates within that incompleteness the complexities of class, gender, marriage, social obligation and a man's consciousness of his own guilt.

A Critical Question

The narrator's gaze repeatedly returns to Malho's body and beauty. A contemporary feminist reading may question this "male gaze." The story, however, also contains the means to criticise that gaze. The more the narrator centres his prestige and desire, the more Malho establishes herself as an independent moral person through her decisions, labour, motherhood and self-restraint. It is this tension that makes the story more complex and modern.

Malho is a poor girl of the Mallah boatmen's caste. After being abandoned by her husband, she works alone to educate her son, Sundar Sahni, who passes the School Leaving Certificate examination in the second division. This detail provides the love story with the concrete ground of class and caste distance.

When they meet in the darkness of night years later, the narrator, possessed by his old sense of entitlement, tries to take her hand. Malho stops him and declares that the future of her son is the centre of her struggle. By once again presenting him with the water lily, she defeats the claim of erotic entitlement on ethical ground.

The poignant expression of this class barrier is found in the words, "I cannot become Janaki." They bring together the pathos of unanswered love, self-sacrifice and social distance.

4.5 "Dhahlel Dalbadalu!" ("The Bungling Party-Switcher!"): Satire upon Moral Compulsion Rather Than Mere Party Defection

At first glance the title signals political satire. Once Chander's story is read, however, it becomes apparent that the writer reverses the popular meaning of "party-switcher." Chander's father supported the democratic changes that followed Rana rule. Although he personally benefited by obtaining a hill landlord's cattle shed cheaply, his support for democracy did not arise solely from self-interest; it was bound up with his experience of liberation from compulsory unpaid labour and feudal fear. Chander makes this ethical inheritance his own conviction.

After 2046 B.S., the leaders of the old struggle become remote in the splendour of office. Chander decides to withdraw from active party work for seven or eight years and merely cast his vote. But his younger brother

Lalchanma gives shelter to a hungry child, and a local *chaite* opportunist frames him on a false charge of kidnapping. Confronted by police torture and political conspiracy, Chander goes to the capital seeking justice from the old leaders who are now ministers, only to be humiliated. The episode is a bitter portrayal of the powerful forgetting the people's memories after democracy's return.

The irony deepens. To secure his brother's release, Chander seeks help from Dr Ramprasad, an influential figure from an old Panchayat family, who makes his assistance conditional upon Chander joining his party. For the sake of his brother's life, Chander agrees. Society immediately labels him a "party-switcher." The writer asks the reader: when justice is obtainable not through institutions but through connections and partisan patronage, does the fault lie only with the person compelled to ask for help, or with the whole structure?

At a later turn, the monarchy once again suppresses democracy. His father's teachings and regret over his own compromise stir within Chander, and he leaps into a procession supporting democracy. The village calls him a "party-switcher" once again—this time for the opposite reason. The word *dhahlel* in the title is ironic: in the public eye Chander is inept at political calculation because, wherever power lies, he chooses the contrary, ethical direction. His final cry of "Long live democracy!" marks the victory of a public value over personal reputation.

The story's greatest strength is its institutional criticism: party organisations, police, ministers, recommendations, political patronage and village gossip form a single web. Its limitation is that, in places, the exposition of political background becomes more essayistic than the movement of the narrative. Chander's personal crisis nevertheless continues to give this discursive expansion an emotional foundation.

During the Panchayat period, Chander's cattle shed had served as a secret refuge for underground democratic fighters. This memory makes the minister's neglect of him in Kathmandu still more bitter. His compulsion to rely on the influential Dr Ramprasad for his brother's freedom appears less a personal defect of character than a consequence of the institutional failure of justice.

One critical reading places the story close to Marxist realism, because the state apparatus and patronage politics force ordinary people into compromises for which the moral blame is eventually placed upon the very person who has suffered.

4.6 "Kari Kobham": From the Gaze upon the Body to Subtle Pain and Existential Crisis

"Kari Kobham" abruptly broadens the collection's geographical horizon. An international workshop, a Black woman facilitator of African origin, training, dance, parties and multicultural conversation bring new air into a fictional world centred on rural Mithila. Initially the narrator pays particular attention to Kari's body size, complexion, hairstyle and the standards by

which beauty is judged. Modern criticism would recognise here the prejudices of the bodily and the male gaze.

The story itself does not permit these prejudices to remain unchallenged. Within moments Kari's vitality, intelligence, skill as a trainer and humour displace the narrator's initial judgement of her body. He wants to emulate her style. In other words, the character ceases to be an objectified body and emerges as an effective professional personality. Even so, as soon as marriage enters the conversation, the narrator once more resorts to a cultural generalisation, assuming that marriage is a condition of "completeness."

Kari's response gives the story an uncomfortable depth. She speaks of the pain associated with her age, the biological limits of motherhood and the difficulty of finding a life partner. The narrator keeps wanting to offer a solution, but in the end is drawn into "subtle pain": for the first time he becomes not the person who supplies answers, but the person who listens. This transformation is what gives the story its significance.

A Reservation from Contemporary Criticism

Kari herself questions the meaning of marriage if motherhood is not possible; this is the voice of her personal experience. A critic cannot treat that statement as a universal truth. To tie a woman's fulfilment to marriage or motherhood is controversial from the perspective of contemporary feminism. The story is valuable because it brings these disputed assumptions into dialogue and gradually dismantles the narrator's confident answers.

Although Kari is described as weighing approximately 110 kilograms, she emerges as a figure of remarkable energy. Her pain concerning the biological limits of motherhood at around forty to forty-five years of age takes the story towards the question of existential loneliness concealed behind a modern career and outward exuberance.

The story presents this biological experience as personal suffering; it should not be regarded as a universal truth about women. Yet, by exploring the complicated tensions among the body, age, marriage, motherhood and self-reliance, it moves beyond Mithila's regional boundaries into a field of global feminist sensibility.

4.7 "Sikandar Dom": Education, Untouchability and the Severe Test of Reformism

"Sikandar Dom" is the collection's most explicit engagement with caste. Varmaji is a progressive teacher who has endured social ostracism for allowing Sikandar into his home. Sikandar is educated, and is presented almost as living proof of Varmaji's efforts. At first, the reader expects the story to become a success narrative about education and an enlightened teacher. The author quickly shatters that complacency.

Sikandar's experience demonstrates that literacy does not in itself dissolve caste structures. At school, a Dom child must sit apart, touching others is forbidden, even the manner in which exercise books are handed over differs,

as does the administration of punishment. The accumulated experience of humiliation makes education not liberation but suffering. Despite his education, Sikandar himself faces discrimination in employment: the question of whether people may touch or drink water that he has touched closes the way to even such ordinary positions as teacher or peon. Thus the story poses a concrete challenge to the simplistic progressive assumption that "education will automatically bring social advancement."

Child marriage, bride-price, caste-based feasting and the refusal to eat "food from a Dom household" reveal the many layers of social oppression. Sikandar's question—where can a person of the Dom caste ever become clean and pure?—reverses the religious logic of purity and pollution. What is impure is not the body but society's way of seeing it.

At the end, Sikandar says that society will change gradually, and Varmaji's wife offers an analogy drawn from the dosage of medicine: administering the entire dose at once may turn it into poison. This is a deliberately uncomfortable ending. From one perspective, it accepts the practical pace of social change; from another, it leaves open the question of how just "gradually" can be as an answer for those who suffer violence every day. The story draws much of its force from this unresolved moral unease.

Sikandar is presented as the first young man from the Dom caste to pass the School Leaving Certificate examination, yet society will not offer him even a peon's job. The question is asked: "Who would drink water from his hands?" He ultimately spends his life working as a night watchman.

To feed the upper-caste teachers invited to his son's wedding, Sikandar has the meal prepared by a professional cook in "the potter's hut" rather than in his own home, so that his Brahmin and Rajput guests can eat. This episode becomes an exceptionally sharp demonstration of the structural depth of untouchability.

4.8 "And She Was Killed!": The Female Body, Love, State Violence and the Murder of Truth amid War

Phuliya's story is the collection's most intense and violent narrative. The shadow of the "People's War," her guerrilla lover Purne, the police, a tea stall, rural poverty, women's lack of education and pressure to marry all converge. Phuliya leaves home while awaiting the fulfilment of her love, but she is not a political combatant. She is a woman caught in a violent conflict that continually appropriates her private life.

Purne, too, is no one-dimensional revolutionary. Gradually he begins to question the limitations of violent "liberation": will killing and fear free society, or will education, dialogue and popular agreement do so? This self-doubt prevents the story from collapsing into a simple opposition between insurgents and the state. The pain of Phuliya's restricted choices, caused by her being denied education—through her parents' assumption that "what would a daughter do by studying?"—reveals a form of social violence parallel to the war.

After Purne's death, the red wedding sari becomes an exceptionally powerful symbol. A garment that had signified the possibility of marriage, home, union and a future turns, in the hands of the police constable Bhulotan, into an instrument of coercion through fear. He demands access to Phuliya's body in exchange for information that would save her. Here a representative of the state is not the protector of the law; he becomes a predator looking for an opportunity to exploit a woman's vulnerability.

Phuliya's resistance—taking up a knife and attacking Bhulotan—is the culminating moment of agency for a defenceless woman, but she is immediately met with a bullet. On the following day, newspapers convert the event into two contradictory political narratives: in one, Phuliya is a "guerrilla heroine"; in another, the constable is a "martyr." The actual story—of love, sexual coercion, fear, self-defence and personal history—vanishes within the political language of news reporting. The title "And She Was Killed!" applies to this double murder: Phuliya's body is killed, and so is her truth.

This story displays the author at his strongest as a political artist. He does not hand the reader the manifesto of any political party. Instead, he shows how the official language of war swallows individual grief. Feminist, anti-war and media-critical readings are all possible simultaneously.

Phuliya's family background includes a plot by a hill landlord of the Karki caste through which her family loses its home and falls into poverty; her father's death through alcoholism; and the entry of her lover, Purne Magar, into the Maoist movement. Purne subsequently becomes disillusioned with violent revolution and tries to escape, but is killed by the police.

Showing Phuliya the red bridal sari found on Purne's dead body, Constable Bhulotan attempts to violate her, declaring, "You will have to let me have you!" Phuliya resists with a knife; Bhulotan fires his gun, and both die. The political news reports of the following day recast this private truth into narratives serving their respective sides.

4.9 "The One-Tusked Elephant and the Nine-Lakh Necklace": A Feminist Re-reading of History

The final story opens with contemporary Mani's unease. After seeing the Sen fort of Makwanpur, the fourteen-year-old princess Indrakumari takes possession of her imagination. Within a nocturnal dream and reverie, the story assumes the form of a courtly drama. This framing device makes clear that history is not being reproduced directly; a consciousness in the present is reimagining it. It is therefore more appropriate to read the story as a literary-historical reinterpretation than as documentary history.

The one-tusked elephant and the nine-lakh necklace are more than objects demanded as dowry. Indrakumari calls them property of the state and the collective inheritance of the people. Her argument clearly marks the boundary between a private marriage and public property. May a king give away the people's inheritance for the prestige of his daughter's marriage? The story brings a modern public ethics into the heart of a feudal monarchy.

Indrakumari's statement—'A woman is not a thing; she is the seed of creation'—becomes the story's defining declaration. A teenage girl being treated as an object of dowry becomes the interpreter of state, culture and self-respect. 'The One-Tusked Elephant and the Nine-Lakh Necklace,' pp. 43–45

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Indrakumari reads Gorkha's demand not simply as a marital disagreement but as an indication of possible cultural and political expansion. She urges her brother Digbandhan to place duty to the motherland above personal feeling. Ultimately he accepts her argument. The dream breaks; Mani's fist remains clenched, but her sister-in-law assumes the cause of her tension to be bodily pain. In this final irony, contemporary society too translates women's political and historical agitation back into the language of the body.

A Critical Caution

The traditional vocabulary of "purity," "womanhood" and "sacrifice" is forcefully present in Indrakumari's speech. A feminist perspective may question these terms, because women's identity cannot be restricted to sexual purity or sacrifice. Nevertheless, from within this inherited vocabulary, the story attempts to make the woman not an object but a political person capable of decision. Recognising this contradiction is necessary for a just criticism of the story.

The historical episode concerns the marriage of Indrakumari, the fourteen-year-old daughter of Hemkarna Sen, the Sen king of Makwanpur, to Prithvi Narayan Shah, king of Gorkha. The demand for a "one-tusked elephant" and a "nine-lakh necklace" as dowry for her second ceremonial journey to her husband's home (*gauna* or *dwiragaman*) produces a conflict among private marriage, the people's patrimony and the honour of the state.

Indrakumari's declaration—"A woman is not a thing; she is the seed of creation. She is the crown of honour and the summit of sacrifice"—becomes a woman's political voice against feudal greed for dowry and expansionist pressure. History often places the victor at its centre; by bringing the moral courage of a teenage princess from the defeated kingdom to the centre, the story constructs an alternative historical reading.

Story	Main Characters	Central Subject / Discourse	Message / Symbol
Depurabali Kaki	Kaki, Misri Kaka	Patriarchy; silent oppression of women	The "Bhishma vow" and masculine pride
Balidani	Central character, Durganand	Democratic disillusionment	Devaluation of martyrdom; chaite opportunism
Patharsanak	Madhu, son,	Political ideals	"Stone" as a

Story	Main Characters	Central Subject / Discourse	Message / Symbol
Lok	husband	versus family	symbol of selfless fighters
Malho	Malho, the householder, Sundar	Class consciousness, noble motherhood	Water lily as a symbol of innocent love
Dhahlel Dalbadalu	Chander, Lalchanma	Democratic loyalty, systemic failure	Party defection as a compulsion
Kari Kobham	Kari Kobham	Biological paradox, existentialism	The global tragedy of womanhood
Sikandar Dom	Sikandar, Varmaji	Dalit discourse, untouchability	Social hypocrisy and education
And She Was Killed!	Phuliya, Bhulotan	State terror, marginalised exploitation	Resistance to sexual violence
The One-Tusked Elephant...	Indrakumari, Mani	Historical re-reading, feminism	Dowry and the dignity of the state

5. Sociological, Philosophical and Political Insights

5.1 Women: Not Images of Endurance but Ethical Centres

Women in the collection frequently suffer, but they are not merely victims. Depurwali Kaki's silence exposes the wrongdoing of masculine pride; Madhu protests openly; despite the memory of old love, Malho gives priority to her self-respect and her son's future; Kari forces the male gaze's easy judgements to encounter subtle pain; Phuliya takes up a weapon to resist the threat of sexual exploitation; and Indrakumari creates a political language of public patrimony and women's identity. Because these female characters are so varied, the collection does not remain a uniform glorification of feminine sacrifice.

Nevertheless, conventional values continue to cast their shadow upon the representation of women in the collection: descriptions of beauty, motherhood, fidelity to one's husband, purity and sacrifice. It would be inappropriate to reach a simple verdict by labelling this duality either a fault or a virtue. Its literary importance is that the work carries within itself the ideological struggles of a society in transition. The language of older ideals of womanhood remains present, while new voices of resistance emerge from within it.

5.2 Democracy: Not a Celebration, but a Continuous Ethical Practice

"Balidani," "Patharsanak Lok ...!" and "Dhahlel Dalbadalu!" can be read together as a trilogy of democracy. The first story depicts the appropriation of the movement's memory and the memory of martyrdom; the second, a

generation of former activists worn down by police violence and partisan decline; the third, the institutional failure of justice and a moral return to resistance against monarchical regression. The author criticises democracy not from an anti-democratic position but in defence of its foundational values.

The most important element in these stories is the memory of lived experience. Those who have known prison, batons, fear and autocracy do not readily accept a return to reactionary rule, however embittered they may be by the corrupt forms democracy has taken. Political conviction is not an abstract proposition borrowed from books; it is a memory of wounds inflicted upon the body. This is why the characters' ethical decisions appear credible.

5.3 Caste and the Subaltern Experience

"Sikandar Dom" is explicitly a story about caste, but subaltern experience is equally deep in "Malho" and "And She Was Killed!" Malho protects her self-respect amid economic and social distance; Phuliya is simultaneously enclosed by multiple forms of deprivation involving education, class, gender and war. The collection repeatedly turns towards those whose names are rarely entered in official history: widows, children, Dom people, abandoned women, poor people caught in false police cases and lovers living amid war.

"Sikandar Dom" particularly demonstrates that the good intentions of a liberal individual are not sufficient to remove structural casteism. Varmaji is important, but the story moves beyond the bounds of his self-satisfaction. The experience of the subaltern person becomes the primary source of knowledge: the student Sikandar is able to speak a harsher social truth than his reformist teacher.

5.4 Memory: From Personal Narrative to Social History

Memory constitutes the foundation of the narrative mechanism in "Depurwali Kaki" and "Malho." A scene in the present—a film photograph, a mother waiting at the doorway—opens onto the past. Here memory is not merely nostalgia. When the narrator recalls the past, he also examines his present moral position. Remembering Malho is not simply remembering an old love; it entails accounting for his own social ascent, the distance that has grown between them, and the responsibilities that remain.

In the same way, "Balidani" and "Dhahlel Dalbadalu!" are grounded in political memory. If the authentic memory of a movement disappears, opportunists will write its history. Memory therefore becomes an instrument of resistance throughout the collection. Private narrative turns into an alternative archive, written at the margins of history.

5.5 Education: Liberation, Opportunity, and an Unfulfilled Promise

Education recurs in several stories. Malho wants her son Sundar to receive an education; Sikandar's life tests the conflict between education and caste; and Phuliya suffers from the restricted choices available to her because she has remained uneducated. Through this recurrence, the collection's social vision establishes education as an important means of emancipation. Yet the author

entertains no naïve optimism. Where institutional discrimination persists, even a school can become a place of humiliation.

5.6 Violence: The Household, Caste, Police, War, and Language

Violence in the collection is not confined to bullets and batons. The lifelong silence of Depurwali Kaki's marriage constitutes psychological violence; the separate seating imposed upon Sikandar's child is caste violence; Lalchanma's false arrest is state violence; the sexual pressure brought to bear upon Phuliya is gendered violence exercised through state power; and the media's political labelling of her personal truth is linguistic violence. By revealing so many forms of violence, the author makes visible the continuity of oppression even beneath the surface of an apparently peaceful society.

5.7 The Micropolitics of Family Relationships and the Larger Structure of Power

The micropolitics of relationships: Lalji's stories demonstrate that the larger politics of society—macropolitics—and the micropolitics of the family are interconnected. In "Depurwali Kaki," Kaka's "Bhishma-like vow" is in fact the domestic form of the same feudal arrogance against which the characters of "Balidani" or "Patharsanak Lok" are fighting in the streets. Just as power is centralised within the country, it is centralised within the family in the form of masculine pride.

5.8 The Irony of Democracy and Systemic Violence

The irony of democracy and systemic violence: "Dhahlel Dalbadalu" and "Sikandar Dom" explicitly convey that neither democracy nor the spread of education, by itself, brings structural violence to an end. Where the institutional system turns its back on people, an ordinary person such as Chander is compelled to compromise with a corrupt order. The failure of the system becomes the cause of individual moral decline.

5.9 Disillusionment with Armed Revolution

Disillusionment with armed revolution: Purne's disillusionment in "And She Was Killed!" and the emergence of Chaite's opportunism in "Balidani" show how a revolution, once institutionalised, can depart from its founding ideals and subject marginalised communities to still greater exploitation.

5.10 Parallel Exploitation of Women's Bodies and the Power of the State

Parallel exploitation of women's bodies and state power: In Lalji's stories, the female body becomes a battlefield. Havildar Bhulotan's desire to "enjoy" Phuliya sexually in "And She Was Killed!" and Prithvi Narayan Shah's wish to acquire Indrakumari through a dowry bargain in "The One-Tusked Elephant..." establish that state power and patriarchy alike regard women as conquered territory. Resistance takes the form of Phuliya's knife and Indrakumari's forceful speech.

6. Narrative Technique, Language, Symbolism, and Characterisation

6.1 The Moral Instability of the First-Person Narrator

Several stories employ an "I" narrator, but the author does not make this narrator omniscient or invariably correct. In "Malho," he worries about his own standing; in "Kari Kobham," he harbours prejudices concerning the body and marriage; and in the political stories, characters regret their decisions. This incompleteness is of literary significance because readers are invited not merely to accept the narrator's words but also to recognise their limitations.

6.2 Dialogue: A Means of Bringing Ideas to Life

Vrishesh Chandra Lal's narrative gift is particularly evident in dialogue. The domestic conversations among the mother, aunt, and Madhu; the hesitant exchanges between Malho and the narrator; the minister's insulting language; the teacher-pupil conversation between Sikandar and Varmaji; the cultural dialogue between Kari and the narrator; and the dramatic argument between Indrakumari and Digbandhan—all allow ideas to emerge through the voices of characters. The author's essayistic impulse can also be felt, but at its most successful, dialogue gives ideas a body, rhythm, and situation.

6.3 Silence, Pauses, and What Remains Half-Said

Some of the collection's finest moments occur when the characters do not say everything. Malho steals sideways glances, offers a flower, and walks away; Depurwali Kaki speaks very little throughout her life; Chander swallows his humiliation and quietly leaves the minister's house; and at the end, Varmaji merely nods his head. Such silences create space for the reader's interpretation. Together, the spoken quality of rural Maithili life and its silences impart a distinctive rhythm to these stories.

6.4 The Structure of Symbols

The water lily—love, distance, dignity blossoming amid mud and water, and an unfulfilled union.

The old photograph or cinematic face—a doorway into memory and the rediscovery of a woman's image.

The red bridal sari—an unfinished marriage, the future of love, the threat of sexual exploitation, and blood.

The one-tusked elephant and the nine-lakh necklace—public heritage versus dowry, the state versus private power.

Waiting at the doorway or threshold—love, family, the hope of return, and time.

These symbols prevent the stories from being reduced to messages alone. The water lily and the red sari, in particular, remain on the reader's mental horizon long after the narratives end. Literary endurance is often created by precisely such visual signs.

6.5 Language: Rural Ease and a Modern Multilingual World

The language of the original text is formed through a combination of colloquial rural Maithili, Nepali political terminology, and modern words of English origin. Terms such as "tea-time," "workshop," "SP," "ministerial quarters," "division," and "computer" are natural components of the modern world inhabited by the stories. Conversely, words such as *durkha*, *goth*, *banihar*, *nuan*, *dabra*, *kumudini*, *bhansia*, *dai*, and *girahat* give the narratives a recognisably local body. It would be mistaken to call this multilingualism an impurity: it is the actual linguistic composition of a borderland society shaped by politics, administration, education, and international contact.

The author alters his language to suit the characters. The minister's speech is an abrasive mixture of the arrogance of power; Sikandar speaks politely, yet with an undercurrent of bitterness; Kari's dialogue belongs to an international culture of training; Indrakumari speaks in a dramatic, Sanskrit-inflected idiom; and Malho's language is brief and rich in implication. These changes of linguistic register prevent the characters from becoming interchangeable mouthpieces for a single author, although his ideological positions are sometimes directly audible in political episodes.

6.6 Memory Frames, Flashbacks, and Stream of Consciousness

In "Depurwali Kaki," "Malho," and "The One-Tusked Elephant and the Nine-Lakh Necklace," ordinary events in the present—a film photograph, arrival in a village, or a dream—open into extensive narratives of the past. In conjunction with these memory frames, some stories approach stream-of-consciousness technique, as an external event sets in motion a sequence of remembrance and inward conversation within a character.

6.7 The Extension of Imagery and Symbolic Design

The water-lily flower, the opposition between an old photograph and television or computer imagery, the red bridal sari, and the one-tusked elephant and nine-lakh necklace are all images that hold together the emotional and intellectual structures of the stories. In "Patharsanak Lok," the "stone" signifies not merely hardness but also steadfastness in principle and a measure of detachment.

6.8 Linguistic Diversity, Indigenous Vocabulary, and Character-Specific Registers

Lalji's language—"pure, lucid, authentically indigenous, and idiomatic"—creates a rich world of local terms such as *durkha*, *asora*, *bhanas*, *jhonti*, *khonchha*, *dagahar*, *goth*, *katiya deb*, *thakmuriya*, *mamori*, *aunayab*, *dhahlel*, *chaite*, *phusiyek pran*, *bhangath*, and *sanes*. Alongside this strongly indigenous base, Nepali administrative vocabulary and modern English-derived terms coexist naturally, revealing the actual multilingualism of the border region. In this dual character of the linguistic world, an earth-rooted locality and the multilingualism of modern contact are present at once.

The author demonstrates particular care in making dialogue appropriate to each character: the everyday speech of village women, the slogan-laden language of political activists, the English-inflected exchanges of an international setting in "Kari Kobham," and the dignified style of historical dramatic dialogue are all successfully created in distinct registers. This is evidence of the author's ability to work with linguistic diversity.

In the original book, footnote explanations of specific cultural or administrative terms—such as *goth*, *khopi*, *bhardar*, and S.L.C.—also make the text more accessible to readers.

6.9 Characterisation and the Representation of Women

The diversity of the female characters is matched by the fact that the male characters are not uniformly drawn. Misri Kaka's final remorse, Chander's ideological conflict, Sikandar's patient struggle, and Digbandhan's sense of duty all possess psychological complexity, preventing these figures from becoming simplistic embodiments of good and evil.

7. Literary Achievements and Critical Limitations

7.1 Principal Achievements

The first achievement is the credibility of human experience. The author's characters are not mechanically conceived ideals. They hesitate, fear, err, repent, love, endure humiliation, and change their decisions. This moral complexity keeps the politically themed stories from becoming propaganda pamphlets.

The second is the placing of women and marginalised people at the centre of history. Calling the martyr's widow and children "those who have sacrificed," making Malho the titular figure of the collection, allowing a Dom character to test the self-satisfaction of a reform-minded teacher, and treating Phuliya's personal truth as more authoritative than an official news account—these choices constitute a literary politics in themselves.

The third is the connection between personal memory and public history. The domestic veranda, field, pool, tea shop, police cell, political platform, and royal court are different places, but human dignity remains the fundamental criterion in every one of them. This unified perspective prevents the collection from appearing fragmented despite its varied subject matter.

The fourth is an accomplished use of irony and symbolism. Kaki dies just as the vow not to leave the house is finally fulfilled; a former democratic minister humiliates a man who seeks justice at his door; Chander is called a turncoat by both sides; Phuliya's red sari and Mani's clenched fist become memorable images in the stories.

7.2 Critical Limitations

In some stories, the weight of ideas bears too heavily upon narrative movement. In particular, lengthy explanations or speeches given to clarify political backgrounds sometimes bring the stories close to essays. Greater

concision, more scenes, and a stronger reliance on dialogue in these passages could have increased their artistic density.

Second, despite the powerful presence of women, traditional images of beauty, motherhood, purity, service, and sacrifice recur. The stories themselves cross the boundaries of these conventions in several places—through Phuliya, Kari, Malho, and Indrakumari—yet contemporary readers will recognise the tension. It is not merely a failing of the collection; it also marks a social consciousness in transition.

Third, the gradual reformism at the conclusion of "Sikandar Dom" leaves uneasy questions unanswered. A small dose of medicine may constitute sociological pragmatism, but from the perspective of a child subjected to the daily indignity of untouchability, such delay can itself perpetuate violence. The story does not fully resolve this contradiction—and perhaps its literary force resides in that very unresolved question.

Fourth, the final story, in its reconstruction of history, idealises nationhood, purity, and femininity. It would be a mistake to treat it as a historically verified reconstruction; understood instead as an imaginative dialogue with contemporary feminist and national consciousness, its literary meaning becomes clearer.

From a critical standpoint, it is also worth considering the tendency in certain stories to "tell" rather than "show." The relationship between the framing narrative and the inner dramatic story in "The One-Tusked Elephant and the Nine-Lakh Necklace" might have been more fully developed, while the ending of "Kari Kobham" feels somewhat abrupt. These limitations do not destroy the works' overall effect, but they offer opportunities for examining their artistic construction.

8. *Malho* in the Context of Maithili Short Fiction

The significance of *Malho* lies not merely in its range of subjects but in its distinctive convergence of Nepali and Mithila experience. The familiar ground of village life, family relationships, caste, marriage, and women's lives in the Maithili short-story tradition here expands to include Nepal's democratic movement, monarchy, Madhesi political experience, Maoist violence, and even the culture of international training. Consequently, the collection's locality is not a limitation: it becomes a credible foundation upon which modern political questions are raised.

The collection's strongest stories—particularly "Malho," "Depurwali Kaki," "And She Was Killed!," "Sikandar Dom," and "Balidani"—succeed at the point where ideas dissolve into scenes and characters. Malho's flower, Kaki's waiting, Sikandar's child at school, Phuliya's sari, and the martyr's widow's silence allow the reader to encounter a human being first; the underlying idea then unfolds of its own accord.

A persistent challenge of political fiction is that characters can become puppets of ideas. Vrishesh Chandra Lal is not entirely free from this risk, but his personal and social experience, command of dialogue, and moral self-

questioning allow principal characters to remain recognisably human at numerous points. Chander, in particular, who changes parties but ultimately returns to his principles, is a memorable character who helps us distinguish political identity from moral loyalty.

9. Overall Conclusion

The fundamental literary achievement of *Malho* is that it reads the history of great events within the lives of ordinary people. The meaning of democracy is found not in the martyr's photograph but in the long years of his widow's loneliness; the claim to abolish caste is tested not in a reformer's speech but in where a Dom child is permitted to sit at school; the truth of revolution resides not in a newspaper headline but in Phuliya's red sari and the knife she uses to defend herself; and the truth of love lies not in a manifesto but in a single water-lily flower.

Again and again, the collection shows power constructing its own narratives: the husband invokes a vow, the party invokes history, the police invoke the law, the media invoke news, and the royal court invokes propriety. Against these narratives, the author sets the experience of the person who has suffered. In the court of literature, that experience offers the more credible testimony. From this perspective, *Malho* is a collection of stories about human dignity.

Malho, the title character, is an apt symbol for the collection as a whole. She is no grand heroine of history but an ordinary working woman from rural society. Yet her silent love, labour, self-respect, and determination to educate her son prove greater than the narrator's status, the passage of time, and social distance. Like the water-lily flower, she blooms amid the reality of mud and water, leaves her fragrance behind, but refuses to become another's possession. Several of the collection's characters—Depurwali Kaki, the martyr's widow, Sikandar, Phuliya, and Indrakumari—extend this dignity in different forms.

Here, the social role of literature appears as an instrument in the hands of a "sharp surgeon": an instrument that dissects political hypocrisy, the cries of the marginalised, and the subtle tragedies of human relationships. In this sense, the convergence of a subaltern perspective, feminist discourse, and democratic consciousness becomes the collection's critical energy.

The meeting of an authentically indigenous local vocabulary with multilingual modern life, the joining of private memory to public history, and the human complexity of characters such as Malho, Depurwali Kaki, Phuliya, Sikandar, and Chander make this collection worthy of sustained literary study.

Final assessment: Malho is a short-story collection situated at the meeting point of social realism, political memory, and women's experience. Its excellence lies not in raising slogans but in discovering subtle signs of human dignity within suffering.

10. Bibliography

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5. *Modiain*

Humanity, Myth, Memory, and the Beauty of Translation

An In-Depth Research-Based Literary Critique, Including Translation Theory

Written by B. P. Koirala

Maithili Adaptation: Vrishesh Chandra Lal

Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham · Bikram Sambat 2061

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Keywords

Modiain; B. P. Koirala; Vrishesh Chandra Lal; Maithili adaptation; humanism; Mahabharata; Bhagavad Gita; opposition to war; women's experience; memory; myth; oral narrative; translation theory; cultural relocation.

1. The Work, Its Editions, Historical-Political Background, and the Author and Translator

In the history of Nepali and Maithili narrative literature, *Modiain* occupies an established place as an enduring, thought-provoking, philosophical, and humanist novella. It was originally written in Nepali by Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala (B. P. Koirala), Nepal's first popularly elected prime minister, a pioneer of its democratic movement, and a major literary figure. Holding literature and politics in creative balance, Koirala presents his political philosophy, the futility of war, and human sensibility in this novella through a mythic framework.

Historically, on 1 Poush 2017 in the Bikram Sambat calendar (December 1960), King Mahendra dissolved Nepal's democratic government and parliament and imprisoned leading democratic politicians, including the popular leader B. P. Koirala. Amid the harsh imprisonment at Sundarijal Prison in Kathmandu, political disappointment, solitude, and philosophical agitation, Koirala turned to literary creation under the pressure of an inner impulse. In that prison, a profound internal conflict was unfolding within him: should the restoration of democracy in Nepal be sought through bloody revolution and armed rebellion, or through nonviolent reconciliation, compassion, and peaceful satyagraha? The philosophical outcome of this ideological struggle is reflected in *Modiain*, which he completed in just three days of imprisonment—28, 29, and 30 January 1964 (15, 16, and 17 Magh 2020 B.S.)—and which was subsequently published by Sajha Prakashan in B.S. 2036 (1980). This is his shortest novel, but in intellectual scope it is exceptionally expansive and serious.

The work was adapted into Maithili by Vrishesh Chandra Lal, a senior figure in Nepal's democratic movement, a thinker, and a public intellectual. His version was published by Sudama Prakashan, Janakpurdham, in B.S. 2061

(2004). The Maithili edition includes the scholarly prefatory writings "A Few Words" by the late Sushil Koirala (a former prime minister of Nepal), "Acknowledgements" by the translator Vrishesh Chandra Lal, "From the Site of Modiain" by Acharya Somdev, and "From the Threshold of Modiain" by Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal"; these establish the book's intellectual seriousness and historical significance. B. P. Koirala himself used to say that he had entered politics through an inner prompting, whereas his entry into literature was of precisely the opposite kind: art demands freedom and embraces not material satisfaction but divine discontent.

Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala was born on 8 September 1914 (24 Bhadra, B.S. 1972) in Kashi, where his family was living in exile. He became a leading figure in Nepal's democratic movement and the country's first elected prime minister, while also being regarded as an epoch-making writer of Nepali fiction, influenced by the psychoanalytic approach of Sigmund Freud. His major novels include *Teen Ghumti*, *Narendra Dai*, *Sumnima*, *Modiain*, *Hitler ra Yahudi*, and *Babu Aama ra Chhora*.

Vrishesh Chandra Lal was born on 29 March 1955. He is himself a committed political follower of B. P. Koirala and an active participant in Nepal's democratic movement, and he continues to write on Nepali politics. In addition to the adaptation under consideration, his publications in Maithili include *Andolan* (a poetry collection), *Malho* (a short-story collection), and *Sanghiyatak Sambandhme* (*On Federalism*, a translation). It is worth observing here that the translator is himself a bearer of the original author's political and ideological tradition. This creates a theoretical and emotional proximity in the act of translation—a "shared ideology"—whose influence is readily apparent in the edition's introductory essays, including those by Acharya Somdev and Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal."

It is also important to note that this is not the only Maithili adaptation of *Modiain*. Dr Ramdayal Rakesh also produced a Maithili version under the same title (B.S. 2054, Safari Nepali Prakashan), while a Hindi translation entitled *Mohi* was published by Ranjana Sharma. Within this tradition of multiple translations, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's adaptation has a distinctive place because of its original linguistic fluency and regional re-creation centred on Darbhanga; these qualities will be considered in detail in the subsequent section devoted to translation theory.

The Nepali original is not reproduced alongside the Maithili edition. Consequently, no conclusive claim can be made about how closely any particular sentence corresponds word for word to the original, where something may have been omitted or added, or precisely what expression was translated by which equivalent. Nevertheless, it is entirely possible to analyse the target text's naturalness, stylistic coherence, cultural adaptation, and paratextual purpose.

2. A Story Within a Story: Memory, Imagination, and Multilayered Design

The work's first major artistic decision is the author's open acknowledgement of the relationship between memory and imagination. An episode from childhood is viewed forty years later through the "telescope of memory"; with the assistance of imagination, an incomplete past acquires sequence and meaning. Thus, from the outset, the reader is told that the text is neither a purely documentary account nor an entirely invented story. It is a joint reconstruction by memory, lived experience, and present consciousness. Through this self-acknowledged uncertainty, the work renders its later dreamlike and mythic expansion believable.

"To arrange an event from the past into a sequence and give it meaning on the basis of memory, the assistance of imagination becomes necessary."

The narrative structure of *Modiain* offers an outstanding psychological example of the "story within a story," or frame-narrative, technique. In its outer frame, the author presents a recollection of his childhood, broadly situated in the 1920s or 1930s. As an inquisitive boy of nine or ten, he travels by train from the Nepal border region to see the city of Darbhanga, accompanied by Misirji, a trusted *gumasta* or agent of his family.

The station, porters, railway, royal palace, horse-drawn *ekka*, dust, the sweet-maker's shop, flattened rice and curd, the thatched grocer's shop, and Haraha Pond: these details do not allow "place" to remain mere background but transform it into a living character. The brightness of noon, the darkness of evening, the changing colour of the pond, a lantern, the trembling flame of an oil lamp, and the sounds of insects together create a psychological stage upon which ordinary reality gradually enters the realm of folk belief and dreams.

Modiain first appears as an affectionate shopkeeper. Her capacity to recognise the child's hunger, exhaustion, and fear immediately is maternal in character. Within this domestic tenderness, the mystery of Haraha Pond opens up. The story of an ancient fisherwoman who sold fish comes first, followed by the Mahabharata narrative at night; finally, Modiain's voice melts into that of a woman from the Mahabharata age named Nari. In this progression, the narrative descends inward from one frame to another.

2.1 The Multilayered Arrangement of Narrative Levels

Narrative Level	Time / Setting	Principal Narrator / Perspective	Primary Significance
Memory frame	Present of the adult narrator	"I"—a recollection of childhood	The coexistence of memory and imagination
Darbhanga frame	A day and night in childhood	The boy + Misirji + Modiain	Local reality, curiosity, and cultural conditioning

Narrative Level	Time / Setting	Principal Narrator / Perspective	Primary Significance
Haraha folktale	Indeterminate ancient past	Modiain's voice	A violent history buried within the landscape
Mahabharata frame	Indraprastha–Hastinapura–Kurukshetra	"Nari"—an ordinary woman	The human cost of the epic for ordinary people
Return to the frame	Early morning / train / Jaynagar	The child's consciousness	An ethical conclusion: become not "heroic" but "good"

3. Circular Structure: From "Great" to "Good"

The work's ethical maxim is introduced very early, at mealtime, in an entirely unforced conversation. The boy says that he will study and become a "great man." Modiain asks him what sort of person a great man is. The boy falls silent. Modiain's reply then becomes the seed of the work's entire philosophy: great people may be of many different kinds, but good people are fundamentally alike everywhere. Therefore, one should strive not to become great, but to become good.

On the final train journey, this seed reverberates once more: abandon the ambition to become great or heroic; become a good human being. The boy's aspiration at the beginning and the dream-voice at the end answer one another. The whole intervening Mahabharata episode appears to be an immense ethical demonstration of that single sentence. "Heroism" that perpetrates mass slaughter, and "greatness" that turns human beings into instruments in the name of power, revenge, or a righteous war, do not constitute moral excellence. This circular construction gives the brief novel a remarkably tight structure.

Here "good" is not an abstract word supplied with a philosophical definition. It means love, compassion, familial closeness, mercy, nonviolence, sensitivity towards the suffering of living people, and the refusal to regard another's life as less valuable than one's own ambition. This ethic endures longer than the work's explicitly argumentative philosophical passages precisely because it is imparted in the language of the home, as the affectionate counsel of a woman.

4. Mythic Retelling, Rebirth, and Existentialism

Modiain is certainly a retelling of the Mahabharata, but its originality lies not in asking "What happened?" but "What happened to whom?" The epic traditionally places dharma, the state, justice, vows, heroism, lineage, divine incarnations, and victory at its centre. Koirala brings to the centre of

narration the countless unnamed lives surrounding that centre: cultivators, displaced people, soldiers' wives, mothers, sisters, and children. The character called Nari ("Woman") is not herself an identifiable canonical character of the Mahabharata; her anonymity is her strength. She is both an individual and the representative of millions of ordinary women whose lives war has devastated.

It is appropriate to call the novel's treatment of myth a "counter-myth" only if we recognise that it does not destroy the Mahabharata, but retrieves another voice suppressed within it. The meaning of the epic's righteous war is transformed into the grief of an ordinary woman. Myth ceases to be an instrument for sanctifying the established order and becomes a laboratory for asking urgent moral questions in the present.

From the standpoint of literary criticism, *Modiain* places the conventionally glorified history of the Mahabharata war upon a new, unexpected, psychological plane. Here the doctrines of rebirth and the immortality of the soul are interpreted from a different existentialist perspective. Just as the conflict between corporealism and spiritualism occupies the centre of B. P. Koirala's novel *Sumnima*, *Modiain* encompasses the story of three births of a single soul.

The novel clearly suggests that the soul's endless journey is not undertaken in pursuit of liberation or spiritual attainment, but arises from an unfulfilled human longing and psychological trauma. The spirit of that unknown Mahabharata-era "Woman," whose husband was killed in the slaughter at Kurukshetra, could find no peace. In a later age she was born as a *Malahin*, a fisherwoman who sold fish beside the pit at Haraha and encountered the tantric practitioner of the Maharaja of Darbhanga. The fisherwoman described to him the gigantic warriors of the Mahabharata age and recounted how an eagle had dropped a corpse. Thereafter the same soul was born in the present age as Modiain, still awaiting her husband. His symbolic presence is suggested by the coughing, ailing grocer, although her true love remains directed towards the soldier-husband of the Mahabharata age.

This spiritual continuity is presented as evidence that, until human justice and fulfilment are attained, the soul continues to wander through the mortal world from age to age. Modiain tells the boy that some thirst, some unfulfilled desire, binds the soul to earthly existence. This is a significant dimension of Koirala's fatalistic and existential inquiry, in which the indomitable force of human desire and love overcomes even death.

4.1 The Fisherwoman and Modiain: Folk Myth and the Mythological–Social Duality

The second pillar of the story is the episode of the *Malahin*. A fish-selling woman offers a tantric practitioner an enigmatic explanation of her laughter, connecting two incidents: an eagle's carrying away a fish, and the dragging of the corpse of a Mahabharata-era warrior as far as Khandavaprastha. Together they form a folk myth. The very process by which the myth is made is

important from a literary-anthropological standpoint. A local body of water, Haraha Pond, acquires its own "sanctity" and "terrifying" quality by establishing a connection with the vast pan-Indian narrative of the Mahabharata. The figures of the fisherwoman and of Modiain–Nari are structurally parallel: both possess "extraordinary" knowledge; both occupy the margins of society; and both give enigmatic, almost incomprehensible answers when confronted by the questions of male authority, represented respectively by the tantric practitioner and Krishna.

5. Ordinary People, Displacement, and the Woman's Perspective

History is habitually written by victors, ruling classes, and patriarchal authority, while the voices of marginalised communities and women are suppressed. In the conventional Mahabharata, the predominant perspective is that of sovereign kings, great warriors, sons of gods, Brahmins, and feudal power. B. P. Koirala, however, reinterprets the calamity of war through the eyes of an entirely ordinary, uneducated yet sensitive woman, Modiain, and of Nari, the young Kshatriya woman of Kurukshetra in the Mahabharata age whose consciousness is intertwined with hers.

Throughout B. P. Koirala's fiction, female characters appear with remarkable strength and revolutionary potential: Indramaya in *Teen Ghumti*, Sumnima in *Sumnima*, Uma in *Babu, Aama ra Chhora*, and Gauri and Munariya in *Narendra Dai*. Similarly, in *Modiain*, this unknown woman occupies the very centre of the plot. These female characters break through patriarchal restraints and seek to fashion independent existences for themselves.

The Nari described in the story is the daughter of an ordinary agrarian Kshatriya family displaced during the establishment of Indraprastha. The clearing of the Khandavaprastha forest for the founding of Indraprastha drove local farming and forest-dwelling families from their homes and impoverished them. This represents the reality of a dispossessed class uprooted by urbanisation and imperial expansion. The woman from the margins views Yudhishthira's staking of Draupadi in the dice game, and the attempted disrobing that followed, from a different perspective. She says, "Draupadi's disrobing is not merely the humiliation of one woman; it is the sign of a great and inevitable calamity!" Rather than dwelling principally on the royal humiliation of Draupadi, her deepest anxiety concerns the catastrophe of the approaching war, which will consume the lives of ordinary people everywhere.

Nari makes clear that the lives of ordinary women, and the *sindoor* signifying their married status, have been staked for the political pride of men: Duryodhana's obstinacy and the desire for revenge associated with Bhima and Draupadi. The female body becomes a principal site of violence and grief in war. The image that emerges at the end of the Kurukshetra war is the culmination of this female tragedy: "It was as though the earth had been emptied of men. Only widowed women seemed to remain alive in this world … clutching their helpless little children to their breasts." This is a poignant revolt of maternal compassion against patriarchal warfare.

In this sense, *Modiain* may also be read as a proto-feminist text. Koirala moves beyond his customary mode, influenced by Freudian psychoanalysis, and attempts to give voice to women's collective suffering.

5.1 A Comparative Arrangement of the Traditional Mahabharata and the Perspective of *Modiain*

Traditional Mahabharata Perspective	Subaltern/Feminist Perspective of *Modiain*
Central figures: Krishna, Arjuna, Yudhishthira, Duryodhana, Bhishma	Central figures: Modiain, the unknown "Woman," ordinary soldiers
Assessment: war is necessary to protect dharma (a righteous war)	Assessment: war is merely destruction and meaningless mass slaughter (holocaust)
Representation of women: symbols of the state's honour; occasions for revenge	Representation of women: the actual victims of war, widows, and restless spirits
Teaching of the Gita: disinterested action (*nishkama karma-yoga*) and the immortality of the soul	Rebuttal of the Gita: destruction of humanity and the imposition of emotionless divinity
Final outcome: justice, the attainment of a kingdom, heaven	Final outcome: mountains of corpses, the peace of a cremation ground, endless waiting

5.2 Contradictions Within the Woman-Centred Perspective

There is, nevertheless, a significant tension within this commitment to women. Nari and her friends regard Draupadi's desire for revenge almost as a departure from "natural womanhood." A morality centred on compassion here risks treating a particular "gentle" image of womanhood as natural. If Draupadi's humiliation, her claim to justice, and her political anger are dismissed merely as incitements to war, another form of female agency may be suppressed. Thus the novel gives women's suffering an extraordinary centrality but does not entirely free its definition of femininity from conventional ideas of propriety. This contradiction is not simply a weakness of the work; it provides an opportunity to understand the complexity of its historical moment, ethical commitments, and gendered imagination.

Modiain raises questions concerning women's needs, oppression, the defence of existence, equality, and empowerment. Its feminism is not identical with a modern discourse of rights; it is primarily a woman's perspective arising from nonviolence, love, domestic life, and respect for human existence. It is therefore more equitable to read its progressiveness and its limitations together.

6. The Gita, Arjuna, and the Tension Between "Humanity and Divinity"

The most revolutionary philosophical and ideological aspect of *Modiain* is its deconstruction, on human grounds, of the traditional doctrine of *karma-yoga* in the *Srimad Bhagavad Gita*. In Indian intellectual and literary

tradition, the Gita is revered as the highest spiritual teaching; Koirala, however, views it through a radically different, humanist lens. This perspective also has affinities with Gandhian pacifism and Ambedkar's concern for social justice, both of which foreground the need to re-examine inherited texts.

When Arjuna sees his kin, teachers, and brothers facing him upon the battlefield of Kurukshetra, he is overcome by despondency and lays down the Gandiva bow. The novelist interprets this distress not as Arjuna's weakness but as the highest expression of humanity. Arjuna becomes the living embodiment of noble human qualities: compassion, sympathy, affection for his people, friendship, parental tenderness, and mercy. His anguished declaration—"No, I shall never kill my own family with my own hands! I do not want a kingdom"—expresses the enduring moral law of the human heart.

Yet Krishna, through the forceful, eloquent, sixteen-chapter philosophical web of argument presented in the Gita, ruthlessly crushes Arjuna's spontaneous human compassion. The arguments that the body is an old garment, that the soul is immortal, that killing without attachment is a religious duty, and that the visible world is *maya*, an illusion, are challenged sternly by Nari–Modiain. In a deeply moving prose passage about human existence, Nari asks Krishna whether her husband's warm embrace, her longing for motherhood, and her grief are also unreal. She argues that, to gods seated in the heights of heaven, mortal life may appear as meaningless and illusory as the lives of insects; but to a human being, and particularly to a woman, life and love can never become irrelevant or false.

The novelist makes clear that divinity and excessive ideology—hyper-ideology—can transform human beings into unfeeling machines. After hearing the Gita, Arjuna "was no longer Arjuna; he had become a machine mounted by God." All his human sensibility had died, and he had been swept into the frenzy of war. The result was that millions of women were widowed, vultures and dogs began tearing at corpses, and humanity itself was defeated.

"O Krishna, what sort of inspiration to duty is this of yours ...? Is human life not already narrowly enclosed within the irresistible boundaries of death?"

This passage approaches modern existentialist thought: it places limited, mortal human existence at the centre and sets it against a certain divine indifference. Acharya Somdev, who wrote a preface to the work, also emphasises this conflict. He observes that Koirala's "political personality seems to have been transformed in the name of humanism." His comment also suggests how deeply the personal experience of an imprisoned political writer —the opposition between *satyagraha* and armed revolution, and between violence and nonviolence—is woven into the philosophical texture of the narrative.

For critical fairness, however, a subtle distinction is necessary. *Modiain* is not a comprehensive philosophical refutation of the Gita; it is a literary rejoinder. The novel tests Krishna's words against a woman's grief and her knowledge of mortality. Its strength, therefore, does not lie in proving that

"the Gita is wrong," but in compelling readers to confront the uncomfortable question of how far human compassion can be suspended in the name of justice, religion, or duty.

7. Opposition to War: Not the Battlefield, but Catastrophe in Every Home

In *Modiain*, the Mahabharata war is not a heroic saga but a machine of death. Throughout the account of the eighteen days of slaughter, the sound "kach ... kach ..." recurs. This onomatopoeia evokes not the glory of swords but the mechanical horror of necks being severed. Mountains of corpses, streams of blood, vultures, jackals, dogs, rotting bodies, and innumerable widows strip war of its ornamental splendour and expose its biological, malodorous reality.

The most affecting argument comes not from the arithmetic of armies, but from the entanglement of human relationships. Nari's husband and brother-in-law fight on the Kaurava side, while her father and brother stand with the Pandavas. Here the meaning of victory and defeat collapses. If the men of one's own family are arrayed in opposing armies, whose "victory" is it? The question dissolves the collective identities of Kaurava and Pandava and places before us the ethics of relationships between individuals.

In the aftermath of war, Nari says that her husband's death also brought about a death within her. Even after bodily death, innumerable widowed souls wander in search of those they loved. These spectral images do not simply introduce the supernatural; they are metaphors of trauma. War may come to an end, but the time of mourning does not. In this sense, Haraha Pond is a site of collective memory: beneath its waters lie buried bones, history, grief, and unanswered waiting. The text enters into a profound dialogue with research on gendered trauma, because violence wounds not only male bodies on the battlefield but the emotional structures of families across generations.

8. Freudian Psychology: Eros versus Thanatos

B. P. Koirala is a pioneer of psychological realism in Nepali literature and was deeply influenced by Freud's psychoanalytic theories. In Freud's account, human beings are governed by two fundamental impulses: Eros, the life instinct associated with love and sexual energy; and Thanatos, the death drive associated with destruction. Koirala himself acknowledged his acceptance of Freudian theory while also granting a place to moralism.

Modiain depicts the intense struggle between these impulses and its consequences with considerable subtlety. Nari's physical beauty, the exhilaration of youth, love born through an exchange of glances with a soldier in the forest, their Gandharva marriage, the tender warmth of her husband's embrace, and her intense longing for motherhood are all expressions of Eros at its height. She finds the fullest meaning of life in the carefree joy of her newly married existence and in laughter, play, and bathing with her female companions beside Suryakunda.

On the other side stand the devastation of war, the struggle for state power, Krishna's exhortation, and the slaughter of the Mahabharata: the terrible

dance of Thanatos. War mercilessly destroys the erotic energy and life instinct represented by Nari. From a Freudian perspective, the Gita's instruction operates as a rational covering through which Arjuna's Eros—his love of family and compassion—is repressed and Thanatos, a destructive force, is awakened. Nari's lament that she has still not been able to bid farewell to her husband is, in fact, an elegy for the premature and unnatural defeat of the life instinct by the death drive.

9. Psychological Trauma, Spectrology, and Performance Studies

The waiting of Nari's soul for her husband across successive ages, embodied in Modiain, symbolically represents post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD) and collective memory following war. In terms of Jacques Derrida's spectrology, or "hauntology," whatever event or experience has not been fully concluded or resolved in history returns as a ghost or spectre to haunt the present. Karl Marx, too, wrote in the *Communist Manifesto* of a "spectre of communism" haunting Europe. Here, the spectre that haunts Modiain is the Mahabharata war.

The sorrow of the widowed woman of Kurukshetra never receives resolution within the course of history. Justice is denied her. She therefore returns as a revenant, entering Modiain's body and awaiting her husband through age after age. The reading offered through spectrology is that the spirits of innocent people killed in war repeatedly disturb history and the present until humanity has genuinely atoned for that violence.

From the standpoint of performance studies, Modiain's telling of the story to a boy of nine or ten constitutes a "performance." Through this performance, she communicates the horrors of war, suffering, estrangement, and the anguish of bereavement to the next generation, represented by the boy. He is both listener and audience, a figure of the future. Even when he falls asleep, the spectre enters his unconscious: in a dream he sees heads being severed to the sound "kach ... kach ... kach" and hears a voice from the sky urging him to become not heroic, but good. This is a striking literary performance of the intergenerational transmission of trauma and the possibility of its alleviation.

10. The Child's Perspective, Orality, and Psychological Credibility

The child-narrator does not diminish the philosophical weight of the work; he makes it credible. At first the boy is excited at the prospect of seeing Darbhanga. The bustle of the railway station, the costliness of the palace, the porters, the sweets, and the ponds are all objects of wonder to him. At night, when darkness, the flicker of an oil lamp, and the "splash" of water increase his fear, listening to Modiain becomes like the familiar domestic experience of falling asleep while hearing a story from one's mother. Myth thereby ceases to be a lecture and turns into a moving picture of dreams.

The even cadence of oral narration, the affectionate address "Baua," the exchanges of questions and answers, the pauses within the story, the movement between sleep and wakefulness, and the merging of scenes into one

another all produce a "credible incredibility." The reader cannot know with certainty whether Modiain really is the ghostly form of Nari, whether the events are imagined in the boy's half-sleep, or whether memory, forty years later, has shaped them into this narrative. The work does not resolve the ambiguity; it makes that uncertainty an aesthetic principle.

This explains why, when the family finally asks what the boy saw in Darbhanga, he answers simply, "Modiain." The palace, the city, the station, and the vehicles have become secondary. The voice of a single woman has left a lasting impression upon the child's ethical consciousness. His journey from outward "seeing" becomes an inward journey towards "understanding."

The original repeatedly uses expressions such as "in a single tone," "hypnosis," and "falling drop by drop." Through such language the author himself calls attention to the nature of his narrative technique. Modiain's storytelling is presented in the manner of a lullaby or a tale from the oral tradition, taking the listening child to the boundary between dream and reality. This stylistic choice is deliberate, for it allows both the reader and the child-listener to experience the very enchantment of "divinity versus humanity" described by the story: Arjuna falls under the spell of Krishna's speech, and the boy under the spell of Modiain's.

II. The Memory of Place, the Mithila Setting, and Language and Style

Haraha Pond, described as still existing in Darbhanga, is the narrative's central "chronotope," or conjunction of time and place. It is a real geographical location; within the story, however, it absorbs memories at three levels—historical (excavations associated with Kurukshetra), mythic (the fisherwoman and the tantric practitioner), and personal (the child's fearful experience of the night)—and becomes a symbol rich in meanings. The physical details of Darbhanga, including the Naulakha palace, the activity of the station, the commotion of porters and their companions, and the grocers' shops, are depicted with realist precision. They give an earthly foundation to the narrative's mythological and philosophical flights. This is a characteristic feature of Koirala's writing, in which romanticism and realism merge.

Darbhanga in this work is not a city on a map, but a city of memory. The noise of the railway station, the palace's red colour, the royal carriage, the elephant stables, the market, the horse-drawn *ekka*, the thatched shop, and flattened rice with curd and jaggery preserve the social texture of an older Mithila in minute scenes. The translator and the writers of the introductory materials particularly emphasise their local relationship with this geography. For a Maithili reader, the work is therefore not merely the translation of a "foreign Nepali book," but a recovery of the reader's own cultural landscape.

Haraha Pond is the work's most accomplished symbol. It is a place for bathing by day, dark water at dusk, a centre of fear at night, a history of bones in the folktale, the buried sorrow of the Mahabharata, and, finally, a site of religious recitation of the Gita. Layer upon layer of meaning is deposited upon the same pond. "Water" here does not bring oblivion; it stores memory. The

story raises to the surface the suppressed history that remains invisible beneath the water.

In this sense, the work creates an anti-monumental monument. The royal palace, whose cost and grandeur travellers take pride in, recedes to the margins of the story with the passage of time; Haraha Pond and Modiain's voice endure. Power builds monuments in stone; ordinary people build them in stories and memory. The novel shows the second form of remembrance to be more enduring.

11.1 Regional Setting, Food, Dress, and Vocabulary

A distinctive attraction of the novel is its vivid regional portrayal of Darbhanga, at the heart of Mithila, in the decades corresponding to the 1920s and 1930s (approximately Vikram Samvat 1980–1990). It recalls the regionalism of Phanishwar Nath Renu and Nagarjun.

The novella offers a pictorial description of Darbhanga railway station in its earlier form: a broad platform covered with a thin layer of tar, a sturdy Calcutta-style bridge, porters pulling large, red-cushioned cane fans, and the clamour of passengers. The detailed depictions of the Maharaja of Darbhanga's "Naulakha Darbar" (the Red Palace of Rajnagar and Darbhanga), elephant stables, horse stables, courts, and the bathing steps of Haraha or Harahi Pond take readers into the living history of Mithila at the time. By connecting the historic Harahi Pond with a pit from the Mahabharata age, the narrative fuses myth and reality.

The Maithili translation is suffused with the aromas of Mithila's traditional food and hospitality. Modiain's shop offers delicious descriptions of puffed flattened rice in a thin brass plate, thick curd, jaggery, *peda* and *laddu*, rice with milk, and freshly fried *bhanta tarua*—aubergine fritters—prepared on the hearth. These details are both sensuously appealing and faithful to cultural experience. The description of Modiain's beauty and dress brings before the reader a recognisably local woman of Mithila. Her clothing—a loose-necked, buttonless printed blouse ending above the navel, an eleven-cubit blue sari, broad silver ornaments on her ears, neck, and feet, armlets, and a hair-bun that repeatedly comes loose—makes the novella as vivid as a visual poem.

The translator, Vrishesh Chandra Lal, employs the vivid, authentic, and rich indigenous vocabulary of Maithili, giving the translation a quality of originality. Words such as *gahinki* (customer), *asorak oriyani* (the edge or eaves of the veranda), *bhanas* (kitchen), *konchiya* (the tucked fold of a dhoti), *bauaini* (wandering), *surael* (rhythmic), *dabara* (small pond), *khadhiya* (pit or trench), *kabandha* (headless torso), *kacharam-badh* (massacre), and *jhapalait* (dozing) heighten the work's literary richness. Such unadulterated regional expression makes the novel's rural and marginalised world more convincing.

11.2 Sound Patterns, Visuality, and Sentence Rhythm

The primary source of the Maithili adaptation's verbal beauty is the ease of its spoken language. Words such as "Baua," "motari," "thehi," "kat," "gam," "mitin," "khissa," "chura-dahi," "bhor," "ghuri," and "bauait" do more than

add local colour; they establish social intimacy within the narration. The speech of the child, Misirji, Modiain, and the village women is free from bookish formality. By contrast, in the Krishna–Arjuna episodes, Sanskrit-derived terms such as *dharma*, *nishkama karma*, *sthita-prajna*, *Paramabrahman*, *Ishvara*, and *kartavya* occur densely. This stylistic duality cannot be dismissed as coincidence. On the linguistic plane itself, the human voice of the household and the scriptural voice of divinity confront one another.

The visual quality is equally noteworthy. The train, the station bridge, the red palace, the darkness of the pond, the shadows cast by the oil lamp, the glittering armour of war, dust, blood, and vultures: the author changes distance and angle as if operating a camera. In the nocturnal passages especially, the opposition of light and darkness governs the child's state of mind. Sounds—the "splash," conch shells, war drums, coughing, the railway, and "kach … kach …"—turn visual scenes into bodily experiences.

In the syntax, many passages move in long, impassioned, repetitive currents. During scenes of war and mourning, these currents create emotional excess; in the child's dialogues, sentences become short and rapid. The style changes pace according to its subject. This variety of rhythms is a major reason why, despite the work's modest dimensions, its narrative time acquires such vastness.

12. Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Adaptation in the Light of Translation Theory

The book itself uses the expression "Maithili adaptation" rather than "translation." "Adaptation" suggests that the aim is not merely to reproduce the words of the original sentences, but to bring the work to life anew in Maithili. In the paratext of the available edition, the adaptor identifies the chief sources of his inspiration as B. P. Koirala's perspective on the Gita, the distinction between humanity and divinity, and the injunction to become a "good person." The function of the target text is therefore also one of ethical and cultural communication.

12.1 Linguistic Proximity and "Sister-Language Transposition"

Nepali and Maithili are closely related members of the Indo-Aryan branch of the Indo-European language family. For centuries, the borderlands of Nepal and India, particularly the Janakpur–Darbhanga region, have been sites of cultural and linguistic exchange. B. P. Koirala himself was connected with Mithila, and his childhood memories extend across Darbhanga and Janakpur, making this translation a natural kind of "homecoming." Owing to this linguistic and cultural closeness, the translation does not encounter the intricate problems of cultural substitution characteristic of translation between distant languages, such as English and Maithili. Instead, it takes the form of a "sister-language transposition," in which the subject matter, symbols, and cultural codes—the Mahabharata, the Gita, Hindu ritual practice, and the geography of Mithila—are shared by both linguistic communities.

12.2 A Strategy of Domestication and Sense-Centred Adaptation

In Venuti's terminology, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's adaptation clearly adopts a strategy of "domestication": it makes the source text so natural for readers in the target language that it appears not to be a translation at all, but an original literary work. Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal," the author of the foreword, bears witness to this when he writes: "I had read the original novel on two occasions; I could not stop until I had read this translation in a single sitting. Because it employs a language and style suited to the nature of Maithili, it immerses the reader in aesthetic pleasure not as a translation but as an original work." This observation suggests that the translator's aim was readability and emotional immediacy, rather than word-for-word fidelity.

Concrete evidence of domestication can be found throughout the text: specifically Maithili forms of address in dialogue ("Baua," "He rau," "Kahandon"); idiomatic turns of phrase in the manner of "Small to behold, but capable of inflicting a serious wound"; and the natural use of regional verb forms and inflections such as "chhaik," "achhi," "rahae," and "kaelanh(i)." The syntax of the original Nepali sentences has thus been thoroughly recast in the patterns of Maithili sentence construction and idiom. In this process the translator has chosen not word-for-word translation, but sense-for-sense translation—a distinction fundamental to translation theory from the classical opposition associated with Cicero and St Jerome to Nida's concept of "dynamic equivalence."

12.3 Nida: Dynamic/Functional Equivalence

Eugene Nida distinguishes "formal" equivalence from "dynamic," or in his later terminology "functional," equivalence, which emphasises a natural and comparable effect upon readers of the target text. To a Maithili reader, the dialogue of *Modiain* sounds entirely natural. The child's speech, the intimacy among women, domestic food, local forms of address, and the vocabulary of rural life convey none of the stiffness of translated sentences. In his foreword, Dr Rajendra Prasad "Vimal" finds the language so natural that the work gives the pleasure of an original composition rather than a translation. This evidence of reception strongly supports the naturalness of the target text.

12.3.1 Textual Examples

Nepali Original (Approximate Sense)	Maithili Adaptation (Vrishesh Chandra Lal)	Translational Feature (Equivalence)
Great people are of many different kinds, but good people are only of one kind.	Who knows how many kinds of great people there are? But good people everywhere are found to be of just one kind!	Dynamic equivalence; a naturally flowing Maithili sentence structure.
Cold / chilly	Warm touch	Cultural adaptation (contextual transcreation).
To weep / lament	Writhing and crying	Emotional

Nepali Original (Approximate Sense)	Maithili Adaptation (Vrishesh Chandra Lal)	Translational Feature (Equivalence)
	out in anguish	intensification.

12.4 Newmark: Balancing Semantic and Communicative Translation

Peter Newmark's distinction between "semantic" and "communicative" translation is helpful here. Domestic conversations, descriptions of scenes, and folktale passages seem predominantly communicative: the Maithili sentences flow as though the story had been told in Maithili from the outset. But when the target text approaches the Gita, philosophical terminology, and Sanskrit verses, it preserves the gravity and technical vocabulary of the source culture. Through this dual strategy, emotional intimacy and philosophical memory are both retained.

12.5 Venuti: Domestication, Foreignisation, and Cultural Repatriation

Lawrence Venuti discusses the tension between "domestication" and "foreignisation" in translation. The Maithili case of *Modiain* differs from the usual example, because the original work's principal present-day frame is itself set in Darbhanga, in Mithila. The activation of local vocabulary in Maithili is therefore not simply a matter of domesticating a foreign text; it restores the story's geographical and cultural sound—a form of restitution or homecoming. At the same time, Sanskrit verses from the Gita, philosophical concepts, and names and forms drawn from the Mahabharata preserve their cultural distance and sanctity. The result is not complete domestication, but a combination of selective homecoming and selective foreignisation.

It is particularly important to recognise that Darbhanga, in India's Mithila region, is the geographical centre of the original Nepali narrative; the source text is therefore already rich in descriptions of a Maithili-speaking area. In these circumstances, the translator's task was not to assimilate "foreign" cultural elements, but to return a narrative written in Nepali, yet fundamentally situated in a Maithili cultural environment, to its "original linguistic home." Viewed in this way, the Maithili adaptation of *Modiain* offers a distinctive and unusual example in translation theory. We might call it "repatriative translation": the translator does not introduce an unfamiliar culture, but restores to largely indigenous material its natural linguistic expression.

The decision to retain Sanskrit verses from the Gita, such as "Nainam chhindanti shastrani ...," unchanged and untranslated is likewise a conscious theoretical choice. It exemplifies Venuti's "foreignisation," maintaining the authority and sanctity of the source language—here Sanskrit—because the Gita verses occupy the status of a "sacred original" within Hindu cultural consciousness, whose translation might be regarded as culturally inappropriate. Thus the translator employs both domestication in the ordinary narrative passages and foreignisation in scriptural quotations according to context, adopting a balanced, "hybrid" translation policy within a single work.

12.6 Toury: Norms of the Target Culture

Gideon Toury's descriptive translation studies attend to acceptability within the target culture. Through colloquial expression, forms of address, verb forms, food culture, and Mithila's local vocabulary, the Maithili adaptation appears to give priority to the norms of the target language. The story's "voice" consequently sounds domestic rather than translated. Acceptability within the target culture is especially necessary because the narrative depends upon oral recollection and a child's act of listening; artificial language would immediately destroy the storytelling technique.

12.7 Skopos: The Translator's Purpose

According to Skopos theory, a translator's strategy should be assessed in relation to its purpose. The adaptor's objective is clear from the paratext: to enable Maithili-speaking readers to appreciate B. P. Koirala's celebrated work; to make a story connected with Mithila available in Maithili; and to communicate anew the ethical teaching that one should become a "good" human being. In view of these purposes, the choice of local, accessible Maithili attentive to both the written text and the sounds of speech is entirely appropriate.

12.8 Lefevere and Rewriting: The Power of Paratext Alongside Translation

André Lefevere regards translation as "rewriting," linked with literary prestige, selection, ideology, and the influence of patronage. In this edition the publisher's statement, the introductions by Acharya Somdev and Dr "Vimal," the adaptor's acknowledgements, and the biographical notes on the author and adaptor all guide readers in advance to regard the work as humanist, anti-war, connected with Mithila, and an achievement of historical significance. The translator does not merely bring over a literary work; he also constructs a framework for its reception. This paratext re-establishes B. P. Koirala within the Maithili literary system.

12.9 Polysystem Theory: Literary Circulation from Nepali into Maithili

According to Itamar Even-Zohar's polysystem perspective, translated literature can take an active part in the development of a target literature, experiments in genre, and circulation between languages. The Maithili adaptation of *Modiain* carries a celebrated Nepali literary work across the India–Nepal border into the Maithili literary sphere. Yet because the narrative is geographically situated in Mithila, this is not a one-way "import," but a renewed circulation within a shared cultural region. Translation thus connects Maithili readers with the philosophical experiments of Nepali modernity, while restoring to them a sense of ownership of the Maithili geography present within the Nepali text.

12.10 The Translator's Visibility, Ideological Affinity, and Possibilities for Textual Criticism

The introductory essays by Acharya Somdev and Dr Vimal emphasise that Vrishesh Chandra Lal is politically a follower of B. P. Koirala's ideology. This

is relevant to the debate in translation studies concerning the translator's "invisibility versus visibility." Although, at the linguistic level, the translator has successfully endeavoured to make himself "invisible"—that is, to make the text read like an original work—his decisions at the ideological level are clearly those of a "visible," intellectually engaged translator. What passages receive emphasis and what interpretation is offered in the introductory materials demonstrate an active presence, transforming translation from supposedly neutral linguistic transfer into an ideological rereading.

A parallel textual comparison of Dr Ramdayal Rakesh's independent Maithili adaptation, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Maithili adaptation, and Ranjana Sharma's Hindi *Mohi* could illuminate language-specific and translator-specific cultural decisions, including dialogue style, forms of address, and the treatment of verses from the Gita.

12.11 A Synthetic Summary of the Theoretical Perspectives

Theory / Thinker	Aspect Applicable to This Adaptation	Critical Conclusion
Nida	Naturalness for target readers; the effect of dialogue	A strong tendency towards functional equivalence
Newmark	Communicative expression in the vernacular; preservation of meaning in philosophy	A balance between two strategies
Venuti	Local Maithili voice alongside classical Sanskrit terminology	Selective domestication/foreignisation; cultural homecoming
Toury	Maithili linguistic and cultural norms	High acceptability within the target culture
Skopos	Accessibility to Maithili readers and ethical communication	Linguistic choices suited to the purpose
Lefevere	Prefaces, acknowledgements, and ideological framing	Literary rewriting accompanies translation
Polysystem	Literary circulation between Nepali and Maithili	Dialogue between cross-border literary systems

13. Principal Achievements, Limitations, and Questions of Textual Criticism in the Adaptation

The natural flow of spoken Maithili: when reading the dialogue, one rarely experiences the stiffness of "translated" sentences.

The restoration of local culture: Darbhanga, Haraha, flattened rice and curd, the *ekka* carriage, village life, forms of address, and folk sounds find their natural home in Maithili.

The preservation of orality: the cadence of Modiain's storytelling, the child's questions, the address "Baua," and the successive stages of fear and sleep remain fluid.

The dignity of philosophical terminology: terms derived from Sanskrit and associated with the Gita, as well as Sanskrit verses, have not been excessively dissolved into colloquial speech.

The wide range of emotional tones: humour, wonder, domestic affection, fear, romantic love, mourning, philosophical dissent, and the horror of war each acquire a distinct linguistic colouring.

The enrichment of the target literature: a distinctive mythic-humanist experiment in the modern Nepali novella has become available to Maithili readers.

The first limitation concerns comparison. Without the original Nepali text, it is impossible to conduct a definitive examination of fidelity at the level of individual words, changes in sentence structure, the preservation of metaphors, omissions or additions, and shifts in meaning. It would therefore be inappropriate to equate naturalness for the target reader with "complete fidelity." The work can certainly be regarded as a successful target text; but conclusions about fine-grained fidelity to the source require a parallel examination of the Nepali original.

Second, an excessive sense of local naturalness—the adaptation's strength—may sometimes reduce the historical or linguistic distance of the source. In the special circumstances of this work, however, the risk appears limited, because the narrative's present-day frame is itself situated in Mithila. Third, the introductory paratexts announce the work's humanist and anti-war meanings very explicitly in advance. Readers consequently encounter a powerful interpretive direction before they can develop an independent alternative reading. A critical edition might have benefited from maintaining greater distance between the literary work and its paratext.

The Maithili adaptation should not be read merely as a secondary copy of the Nepali original. In this edition language itself creates meaning. Darbhanga and Mithila, which form the narrative landscape of the source, regain the sounds, addresses, food culture, and oral rhythms of their locality when expressed in Maithili. The translator's role is thus not only that of a "bridge," but also one of cultural reclamation. At this point translation studies opens a new avenue into literary criticism of *Modiain*.

15. Principal Symbols of the Work and Their Meanings

Haraha Pond — a reservoir of buried history, bones, collective memory, grief, and myth.

Darkness and the oil lamp — childhood fear and the threshold between consciousness and unconsciousness; a gateway from reality into dream.

The train — an outward journey accompanied by inward moral change; altered consciousness on the return from Darbhanga to Jaynagar.

Vultures, jackals, and dogs — counter-images that bring the "heroic" discourse of war down to the biological reality of corpses.

Gandiva — the shifting relationship between individual judgement and obedience to ideological commands.

The voice of the Gita — the enduring tension between the authority of scripture and a woman's human questioning.

The "good person" — the ethical principle joining the beginning and end of the work; an alternative to greatness and heroism.

16. Overall Evaluation According to Stylistic Criteria

In terms of narrative construction, *Modiain* is highly successful. The memory frame, the journey, local reality, folktale, dream, Mahabharata, and return are not disconnected pieces, but concentric circles leading gradually towards greater depths. The Mahabharata section contains an enormous number of figures, yet the narrative does not scatter, because its emotional centre remains fixed upon Modiain/Woman and the child.

Philosophically, the work deliberately adopts an emotional intensity weighted towards one side. The compassion of Woman is accorded a higher moral standing than Krishna's reasoning; this is not "impartial philosophical debate," but an artistic ethical intervention. Such partisanship is not necessarily a defect in a literary work; indeed, it sharpens the question being asked. Readers must nevertheless recognise that a comprehensive debate on the philosophy of the Gita is not the purpose of this short novel.

Psychologically, the combination of childhood memory, fear, half-sleep, voices, and the dissolution of one scene into another is outstanding. Socially, the displacement caused by the construction of Indraprastha, unemployment, labour, women's lives, and the domestic cost of warfare establish the work's modernity. From a gender perspective, the centrality given to women's experience is historically important, although the notion of "natural womanhood" calls for contemporary critical scrutiny.

From the perspective of the Maithili adaptation, the reader's greatest gain is that the work finds the speech and sensibility of its own geographical setting. In this respect, Vrishesh Chandra Lal's achievement meets the demanding standard of literary translation by which the target language does not remain a shadow of the original, but becomes a living literary body in its own right. Nevertheless, a parallel study of the original Nepali will remain essential for any rigorous source–target comparison in future scholarship.

17. Conclusion and Contemporary Relevance

Although *Modiain*, written by B. P. Koirala and translated into Maithili by Vrishesh Chandra Lal, is a novella of modest dimensions—only forty-two pages—it possesses epic seriousness in intellectual, philosophical, and literary terms. It is not merely a retelling of a mythological story, but a severe and unsparing psychological documentation of the horrors of war, the destruction of humanity in the name of divinity, and the tragedy of marginalised groups, particularly women.

The true power of *Modiain* resides as much in its narrative art as in its intellectual courage. Had it simply declared that "war is bad," the work would have become a sermon. Had it merely presented arguments against the Gita, it would have been a philosophical pamphlet. Instead, through a child, an affectionate woman, a dark pond, a story told at night, a displaced family, a loving marriage, a group of frightened women, and finally a Kurukshetra filled with corpses, Koirala gives abstract questions a body, voice, smell, and memory. Thought is consequently not separate from the story: the story itself becomes thought.

The work does not diminish the Mahabharata; it makes the epic greater by viewing it from another angle. Alongside the history of kings and gods, it places the history of unnamed people. Arjuna's compassion, Woman's fear, the widow's waiting, and the child's ethical education together suggest that humanity is not the enemy of religion, heroism, or greatness, but their ultimate test. If a supposedly "great" deed renders millions of ordinary lives meaningless, its greatness must be reassessed. This is the work's most difficult question.

The Maithili adaptation gives this question an exceptionally natural voice within the reading world of Mithila. Vrishesh Chandra Lal balances the intimacy of the target language, the rhythms of conversation, local cultural substance, and the dignity of philosophical terminology. From the standpoint of translation theory, the work is a successful example of functional equivalence, communicability, acceptability within the target culture, purposive translation, and literary rewriting. Because the story is set in Darbhanga, it is especially meaningful to describe the adaptation as a "cultural homecoming."

In the contemporary world, when the horrors of war, genocide, and destruction driven by arrogance have spread across different regions, the humanist appeal of *Modiain* has become still more relevant. Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Maithili translation has not only strengthened the cultural and literary bridge between Nepali and Maithili, but also proved an invaluable contribution to Maithili narrative literature, one that will continue to be read and researched across the ages for its dynamic equivalence and regional language and style.

The novel's final words—"Baua, become great; never try to become a hero. Become a good person, good … wonderful!"—become an enduring

Upanishadic *mahavakya*, or great utterance, for all humanity. They embody a fundamental Gandhian injunction towards peace and human welfare.

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6. Sumnima

A Comprehensive Literary and Translation-Theoretical Critique of Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Maithili Adaptation of Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala's *Sumnima*

Maithili Adaptation: Vrishesh Chandra Lal

Critical Study: Literature · Psychoanalysis · Culture · Translation Theory

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Research-Based Critical Review

August 2026

Abstract

This review reads Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Maithili adaptation of Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala's *Sumnima* from literary, psychoanalytic, sociological, ethnic, feminist, ecological and translation-theoretical perspectives. It argues that the work's central tension is not the simple binary of body versus soul, but the question of cultural purity versus human coexistence. Somdatt's repression of the body, Sumnima's experiential understanding of life, Puloma's suffering within marriage, and the mixed cultural relationship of the next generation together expose the impossibility of a "pure" identity. The Maithili adaptation is evaluated in the light of Nida, Newmark, Venuti, Catford, Bassnett, Toury and Skopos-oriented approaches.

The conclusion is that the adaptation is highly accomplished in its communication of feeling, character speech, vernacular rhythms and cultural registers. A glossary, source references and a translator's commentary would also be valuable in a future critical Unicode edition.

Keywords: Sumnima · B. P. Koirala · Vrishesh Chandra Lal · Maithili translation · body and soul · Arya and Kirat · psychoanalysis · ecofeminism · ethnic consciousness · translation theory

Research basis: The complete text and paratext of the available Maithili edition; published research including Bhanubhakta Sharma Kandel (ethnic consciousness), Indira Acharya Mishra (ecofeminism), Hariprasad Silwal (sociology), Kamal Prasad Phuyal (body/self) and Prakash Chandra Khatri (psychoanalysis); and major concepts in translation studies advanced by Nida, Newmark, Catford, Venuti, Bassnett, Toury and Munday.

Essential Bibliographical Information

Original work	Sumnima (Nepali novel), author: Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala
Maithili adaptation	Vrishesh Chandra Lal
Genre	Novel (Maithili adaptation)
Publisher	Phoenix Books, Baneshwar, Kathmandu, Nepal
Edition	First, Ashoj 2078 B.S. (September 2021)
ISBN	978-9937-705-59-2
Cover illustration / art	Rajan Kafle (illustration), Saraswati Chaudhary (art)
Prefaces	Pradip Giri and Dr Shephalika Verma
Number of pages	154
Work	**Sumnima**
Author	Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala
Maithili adaptation	Vrishesh Chandra Lal
Publisher	Phoenix Books, Baneshwar, Kathmandu, Nepal
Edition	First, Ashoj 2078 B.S. (2021 CE)
ISBN	978-9937-705-59-2

1. Introduction: More Than a Love Story, a Test of Civilisational Consciousness

To read Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala's *Sumnima* merely as a love story, a psychosexual narrative or an Arya–Kirat conflict would diminish the scope of its imaginative achievement. The novel constitutes an extended debate between body and soul, nature and culture, matriarchal and patriarchal understandings of society, spontaneous pleasure and disciplined asceticism,

individual desire and communal codes, ethnic memory and a shared future. In the Maithili adaptation, this debate takes place not only at the level of subject matter but also within language itself. Somdatt's Sanskritised, scriptural and disciplined speech, and Sumnima's spontaneous, earthy, bodily and direct voice, give two distinct philosophies of life their linguistic embodiment.

What distinguishes this edition is that the Maithili translation itself becomes a cultural event. The adaptation of a celebrated work of Nepali literature into Maithili brings questions of centre and periphery, "national language" and mother tongue, classical authority and vernacular culture onto new ground within Nepal's multilingual literary sphere. The publisher's note and introductory essays view this translation in the context of linguistic equality, cultural plurality and national coexistence. This review therefore accords equal importance to the literary value of the original narrative and to the translator's linguistic and cultural strategies.

The Author's Literary and Political Background

Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala (1971–2039 B.S.) was, on the one hand, Nepal's first popularly elected prime minister and, on the other, an epoch-making writer who pioneered psychoanalytic realism in Nepali literature. He liked to describe himself as a socialist in politics and an anarchist in literature. His life in freedom appears to have been chiefly devoted to politics, whereas his life in imprisonment was devoted to literary creation. Experiences ranging from his forced recruitment into military service by the British government during the Second World War to the founding of the Nepali National Congress in 2003 B.S., and his removal from office by King Mahendra in 2017 B.S., gave depth to his thinking.

Koirala began his literary journey by publishing the Hindi short story "Vahan" in *Hans* in 1987. He introduced into Nepali fiction the influence of psychoanalysts such as Freud, Jung and Adler. The difficulties he faced under the country's prevailing authoritarian political order led him to turn away from overtly political and social subjects and to make the individual psyche and the human unconscious the principal concerns of his literature. In works such as *Teen Ghumti*, *Narendra Dai*, *Modiain*, *Hitler ra Yahudi* and *Babu, Aama ra Chhora*, he addressed sexual psychology, the philosophy of the Gita and humanism. *Sumnima*, however, is of a different kind. Whereas *Teen Ghumti* explores the vicissitudes of a woman's life, and *Narendra Dai* the tragedy of relations between women and men, *Sumnima* is primarily a narrative founded upon the conflict of two distinct cultures. Koirala composed it while imprisoned in Sundarijal Jail with Ganesh Man Singh, Krishna Prasad Bhattarai, Ram Narayan Mishra and Dewan Singh Rai, drawing inspiration from their discussions between spiritualist and materialist outlooks.

His literary output—six novels, two short-story collections, an autobiography and prison diaries—is inseparable from his political life. In the intellectual atmosphere of Sundarijal prison, Dewan Singh Rai represented a Kirati materialist perspective and Ram Narayan Mishra a religious-spiritualist

one. The influence of their heated discussions is discernible in the conceptual structure of *Sumnima*.

Methodologically, the present study reads together the complete text of the available Maithili edition, its publisher's note, the translator's statement, Pradip Giri's preface, Shephalika Verma's commentary, and modern research on *Sumnima* addressing ethnic consciousness, sociology, studies of embodiment, psychoanalysis and ecofeminism. In the translation-theory section, the target text is assessed through the ideas of Nida, Newmark, Catford, Venuti, Bassnett, Toury and Skopos-centred approaches. One limitation must be made explicit: a line-by-line comparative copy of the Nepali original was not available for this review. Consequently, no definitive claim is made about "verbal equivalence with the source." The assessment rests instead on the Maithili target text, the translator's declared principles, the work's known narrative structure and critical scholarship.

2. The Textual Context, Composition and Significance of the Edition

The available edition identifies the book as *Sumnima*, its author as Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala and its "Maithili adaptation" as the work of Vrishesh Chandra Lal. It was published by Phoenix Books, Baneshwar, Kathmandu; its first edition is dated Ashoj 2078 B.S. (2021 CE), and its ISBN is 978-9937-705-59-2. At the end of the book, the author himself gives the place of composition as "Sundarijal, Prison" and a span of eight days, 21–28 June 1964. This is important for understanding both the brief period of its composition and its inner intensity: the novel's narrative compass is relatively narrow, but its conceptual tensions are extraordinarily dense.

It would be unwise to turn the prison setting mechanically into a political allegory. Nevertheless, questions of "liberation" and "bondage" repeatedly return in the novel. Somdatt treats the body as a fetter and seeks to repress it, only to discover ultimately that rigorous spiritual practice can itself become another form of bondage. Sumnima, who belongs to a socially marginalised community conventionally designated "non-Aryan," proposes an alternative conception of freedom through an unforced acceptance of the body and nature. Thus the author's political imprisonment and the character's spiritual self-imprisonment are not direct equivalents, but they certainly create a profound resonance around the question of freedom.

The Maithili edition's paratext is equally significant. The publisher's note raises the question of the dominance of Khas Nepali and the neglect of other mother tongues in Nepal's multilingual reality. Pradip Giri considers the translation through nationalism, Mithila, the Kirats, Madhesh and cultural diversity. These framing texts lead readers to see the Arya–Kirat conflict not only as an ancient mythical episode but also as a question of modern multilingual nation-building. The paratext enriches the novel, but also calls for caution: its political introductions must not imprison the novel's richly multiple meanings within a single ideological conclusion. The achievement of *Sumnima* lies precisely in its capacity to interrogate the self-assurance of all sides.

The Mythological and Geographical Basis of the Setting

The novel opens with an introductory tale that establishes its setting through a geographical and mythological account of the Kaushiki River and Varahakshetra. The place acquires historical and mythic dignity through references to Vishwamitra's hermitage, the education of Rama and Lakshmana, and Sita's *swayamvara*. Against this background the central story unfolds: the childhood companionship of Somdatt, a Brahmin boy, and Sumnima, a Kirati girl, gradually develops into a complex journey of attraction and repulsion.

At the centre of the story stands an elemental conflict between two civilisations: Brahmin-Arya culture, which regards the cow as a mother who must not be killed, privileges the soul and treats the body merely as a means; and Kirat-Bhil culture, which accepts the cow as food and regards the body as both beginning and end. In effect, this conflict is a narrative reworking of the classical debate between Vedic philosophy and Charvaka/Lokayata thought: scripture grows arid while life elsewhere remains full of green vitality.

3. Narrative Structure: Encounter, Prohibition, Repression, Return and Succession

The novel has a circular structure. At its beginning the children Somdatt and Sumnima meet near the Kaushiki River, a *shami* tree and the surrounding forest. At its end, the next generation's love develops within the same natural setting. This recurrence is more than a device of plotting; it is the author's central argument. Civilisations formulate rules, memory hardens them, yet nature ceaselessly creates the possibility of new relationships. The old hermitage falls into ruin and is absorbed by the forest, while a new mingling of love and blood continues through the next generation.

The first part begins with the curiosity of childhood. In the conversations between Sumnima and Somdatt, questions about the precedence of motherhood and fatherhood, cows, meat, religion, nakedness, language, gods and human beings become philosophical debates, yet the author keeps them within the wonder of children. Thought therefore does not turn into instruction: it emerges from character. When Sumnima asks whether one should first recognise the mother who gives birth or the father, Somdatt responds with a scriptural, patrilineal explanation. The seed of the whole novel lies here: experience against doctrine.

In adolescence, this debate becomes an experience of the body. Somdatt's attraction, fear and repression intensify his ascetic discipline. The work's short second chapter, in which Somdatt leaves the hermitage, forms its philosophical centre. The writer of the preface likewise regards this chapter as its "kernel." The question is not whether austerity is true or false. It is what spiritual worth remains when austerity becomes an instrument for defending the ego.

In the third part, Somdatt returns from severe ascetic practice and marries. His marriage to Puloma, the obligation to produce offspring, the notion of

the body as no more than an instrument for extending the lineage, and the mental image of Sumnima together poison conjugal life. Denying the body does not destroy it; desire changes form and remains active in the unconscious. Ultimately both Somdatt and Puloma experience physical pleasure through imagined figures outside their marriage. Here the novel achieves its psychoanalytic depth.

The epilogue brings Puloma's death, Somdatt's final repentance, Sumnima's maternal affection and the union of their children into a new cultural synthesis. Yet this is no simple happy ending. Sumnima herself wonders how the Brahmin tendency to "take flight into the air" and the Kirati attachment to "earth" can remain together. Her blessing states the fundamental condition of reconciliation: each must understand the other's path and, when necessary, alter their own. The novel's resolution is therefore not purity but accommodation; the victor is neither culture in isolation, but a mixed culture capable of dialogue.

4. Somdatt: Ascetic, Proud, Tormented and Ultimately an Incomplete Human Being

To read Somdatt merely as a "Brahminical villain" would destroy the novel's psychological complexity. From childhood he is trained in discipline, sacrifice, celibacy, Vedic recitation, repression of the body and the superiority of the paternal lineage. His personality is formed less by independent experience than by inherited principles. His severity is therefore not simply personal malice but a profound internalisation of cultural conditioning. The author finds him culpable while also showing the reasons for his tragedy.

Somdatt's central conflict is not "desire versus duty," but "acknowledging the existence of desire versus denying it." Had he acknowledged his attraction and made decisions within the constraints of duty, the conflict would have been less acute. Instead, he regards desire as impure, and his consciousness becomes a battlefield waging war against desire itself. Sumnima's touch is less an external temptation than a shock of self-knowledge: for the first time he discovers that his body is not wholly subordinate to his principles. Rather than turn this defeat into self-revision, he turns it into self-punishment.

This is particularly important in a psychoanalytic reading. In Freudian terms, repressed desire does not disappear; it returns. The modern scholar Prakash Chandra Khatri reads *Sumnima* through the unconscious, sexual longing and repression. Events in the novel support this reading: Somdatt undergoes the harshest austerities, but cannot efface Sumnima's image; even after marriage he mentally summons Sumnima during physical relations with Puloma; and, upon seeing his son, he links the idea of a "mental conception" to Sumnima. The denial of the body thus becomes an all-pervasive mental image of the body.

A second dimension of Somdatt's tragedy is pride. His scriptural knowledge gives him not humility but a sense of superiority. His belief that Sumnima's community is "uncultivated," "barbaric" and "bestial" is the ethical failure of

that knowledge. The novel's short second chapter raises the question directly: is asceticism, under the name of *brahmatejas* or spiritual radiance, merely a means of accumulating pride? Such self-interrogation prevents the novel from becoming propaganda. The author undermines his Brahmin character from within.

Nevertheless, Somdatt ultimately possesses human compassion. His affection for his son surfaces from time to time; on his deathbed he regards his life as a pursuit of a mirage; Sumnima's voice opens an indistinct realm of happiness in his final consciousness. Such remorse does not erase his wrongdoing, but it makes the character a living human being. Somdatt's failure is the crucial evidence for the author's argument: if human beings deny the basic experiences of humanity—love, the body, affection and companionship—in order to defend a principle, the principle itself will ultimately become empty.

A Critical Counterpoint on the Portrayal of Somdatt

By way of comparison, the writer of the preface concedes that Koirala has been somewhat unjust to Somdatt, depicting him as a helpless, poorly educated and obstinate Brahmin youth. Somdatt's life is filled with a dry and burdensome sense of duty; he lives in disappointment and dies in disappointment. This imbalance may be regarded as one limitation of the novel, though it also clearly signals the author's ideological preference for a natural philosophy of life over doctrinaire spiritualism.

5. Sumnima: Not Merely an Image of Nature but the Bearer of an Alternative Knowledge Tradition

To reduce Sumnima to a straightforward symbol of “nature,” “body,” “woman” or “Kirat” would overlook the active intelligence of her personality. She questions, argues, suffers injury, preserves her self-respect, marries, fulfils her responsibilities as a mother and eventually gives the next generation a philosophy of life. Her knowledge is experiential rather than derived from books; the author, however, does not confuse experiential knowledge with ignorance. On the contrary, Somdatt's “knowledge” repeatedly loses to life, while Sumnima's spontaneous intelligence grasps practical truth.

Sumnima's childhood questions—about the relation between mother and father, the need for human beings to speak a human language, and the wrongness of destroying people in the name of religion—contain the seeds of her intellectual maturity. They emerge not in the language of modern liberalism, but in the unforced voice of popular wisdom. That is why she does not become the mouthpiece of an ideology. She does not regard the body as a crime; nakedness is not a source of shame to her, for the body is a natural part of life.

Kamal Prasad Phuyal's study of “disembodiment/re-embodiment” reads the novel as a struggle between a disembodied conception of the self and the recovery of embodiment. This perspective challenges the tendency to treat Sumnima merely as a woman who arouses sexual desire. She becomes the

means of Somdatt's "re-embodiment": she reminds him that spirituality becomes lifeless when the soul is entirely severed from human experience. Caution is nevertheless necessary. If Sumnima is made into nothing more than an instrument for a man's spiritual healing, her independent existence is again lost. By giving her maternal, social and moral personhood in the final part, the novel largely avoids this difficulty.

Sumnima's metaphor of "earth" is significant. At the end she tells her daughter that the Kirati people are creatures of the earth, for whom enjoyment, pleasure and the body are fundamental. It would be dangerous to interpret this as a biological destiny assigned to an ethnic group. In literary terms, the metaphor sets an earth-bound understanding of life against a flight into limitless emptiness. Since Sumnima herself supports a marriage across cultural boundaries, her statement is better understood as a poetic figure for cultural inclination than as a rigid racial theory.

Her greatest moral victory is her refusal of revenge. Somdatt rejects her love and thereafter carries her image throughout his life. Yet she comes to see him on his deathbed, takes his orphaned son into her home and accepts his union with her own daughter. Compassion here is not a passive characteristic of "nature," but an active ethic that interrupts the violence of history.

Sumnima in the Eyes of the Preface Writer

In the words of Pradip Giri, who wrote the preface, Sumnima is the most natural, spontaneous and vivid of all Koirala's characters—an exuberant embodiment of the primordial and inevitable attraction between woman and man. Her playfulness, talkativeness and captivating beauty are compared with the celebrated dialogue of Shuka and Rambha in Sanskrit poetry. She represents a culture of nature, without scriptural learning but endowed with a philosophy of life. Although, after marriage, her conjugal life is the reverse of a life fulfilled by natural love, she obtains satisfaction through the discharge of her responsibilities. This makes her not a tragic figure but a resilient, life-affirming one.

6. Puloma: The Novel's Most Painful Silence and the Question of Women's Rights

Discussions of *Sumnima* generally concentrate on Sumnima and Somdatt, but without Puloma a psychoanalytic or feminist reading of the work remains incomplete. Puloma belongs to Somdatt's own cultural community and is therefore, in principle, a "suitable" wife; even so, their marriage fails. This failure makes clear that the problem is not simply an attraction between ethnic groups, but Somdatt's fundamental attitude towards the body and love.

For Somdatt, marriage is a means of repaying his debt to his ancestors. His wife is not a companion but a "field" for the production of offspring. Such language exposes the cruelty of a patriarchal conception of the body. Puloma's desire, fear, expectations and humiliation are all diminished against the background of religious duty. As the couple struggle to produce a child, the burden of spiritual discipline grows upon both their bodies. Desire ceases to be

the natural exchange of love and becomes a field of imagined substitutes, guilt and jealousy.

Indira Acharya Mishra's ecofeminist study identifies the patriarchal hierarchy of such binaries as woman/nature and man/culture, body/soul and pleasure/restraint in *Sumnima*. Puloma's life reveals the internal violence of this structure. Sumnima is the outsider, the "other," and so has opportunities to resist; Puloma is an insider, one of "our own," and is therefore more tightly bound in the name of scriptural propriety. Her suffering demonstrates that belonging to the "same culture" does not automatically produce equality.

Puloma's psychological experience—finding bodily pleasure and conceiving a child through the imagined presence of a Bhil man, followed by Somdatt's humiliation and their mutual loathing—is among the novel's boldest and most controversial passages. Reading this merely as sensationalism or "adultery" is inadequate. The author shows how structures of repression ultimately create a secret domain of imagination in which persons fulfil their forbidden desires. Puloma's mental autonomy offers a severe commentary on the failure of her marriage.

The work's limitations also appear here. Puloma's inner life is less fully developed than Sumnima's, and she sometimes becomes a device for intensifying Somdatt's psychological crisis. A contemporary feminist reading demands fuller attention to her independent story, postpartum neglect, labour, mental health and social isolation. In the epilogue, the gradual wasting away of the ailing Puloma seems like the residue of a patriarchal marriage that demands lineage from a woman's body without providing a social framework for her care.

7. The Body–Soul Debate: The Defeat of Dualism and the Search for Balance

The novel's central philosophical question is not "Which is superior, body or soul?" Had the author intended merely to proclaim the victory of materialism, there would have been no need for the final synthesis. What the novel actually proposes is that human beings are diminished by treating either body or soul as the whole truth. Somdatt denies the body in order to preserve the soul; the result is a soul trapped in pride, repression and emptiness. Sumnima accepts the body's spontaneity and the ease of living; yet at the end she advises her daughter to understand the "flight" of Somdatt's son. In other words, Sumnima too recognises that a human being is not merely earth but also aspiration.

Phuyal's study describes this synthesis as a "middle balance" between "disembodiment" and "re-embodiment." Such a reading accords with the novel's final scenes. In the love of the next generation, the Brahmin son grows up in Kirati society but remains drawn towards the ruined remnants of the hermitage. He does not adopt the old culture, yet he does not wholly erase memory. His identity is mixed: his feet on the earth and his gaze towards the sky.

Throughout the novel, the language of the body repeatedly becomes a language of knowledge. Touch, nakedness, sweat, hunger, milk, meat, the body wasted by austerity, pregnancy, childbirth, illness and embraces are not merely physical descriptions; they are evidence within an argument. Somdatt's scriptural assertions collide with the direct experience of the body. In literary terms, this is an exceptionally successful method, for it renders abstract philosophy in embodied scenes.

That is why the eroticism of *Sumnima* is not obscenity but epistemology. The question is how human beings come to know the truth: through books, tradition, mantras and reason—or also through touch, suffering, love, failure and the limits of the body? The novel's answer is: through both. But if the first prohibits the second, knowledge remains incomplete.

Freudian Id, Ego and Superego, Repression, and the Discourse of "From Sexual Union to Samadhi"

Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala is regarded as a pioneer of the psychoanalytic current in Nepali literature. *Sumnima* is built on a Freudian psychological foundation, in which the three principal agencies of the human psyche—the id, ego and superego—are vividly represented through the characters.

Sumnima represents the "id." According to Freud, the id is the part of the human mind governed by natural desires, sexual drive (*libido*) and the pleasure principle. Sumnima's entire philosophy of life rests upon this pleasure principle. She bathes naked in the Koshi River, delights in nature and does not consider sexuality sinful. On the other hand, Somdatt's father Suryadatt, Puloma and the whole body of Arya religious scriptures symbolise the "superego"—morality and social rules—which sternly commands the repression of the senses. Somdatt himself is the "ego," continually struggling between natural desire (his attraction to Sumnima) and spiritual duty (ascetic discipline).

Somdatt tries forcibly to repress his sexual desire. Freudian theory holds that a repressed wish never disappears but accumulates in the unconscious and may manifest itself as psychological disturbance or neurosis. Even at the height of his austerities, Sumnima's naked, gold-gleaming body disturbs Somdatt's meditation. He says, "This body of yours is the very form of sin; it is poison, it is filth. Remove this hell from before me!" This is the voice of his "superego," terrified of the "id" within him.

When Somdatt performs the *putreshti yajna* with his wife Puloma in order to beget a child, he makes sexual relations wholly mechanical and devoid of feeling. He explicitly instructs her that "if consciousness of the bodily element produces an experience of physical pleasure, the purpose of the duty of intercourse is lost." Such enforced sexual union without love leaves both Puloma and Somdatt frustrated. Dr Shephalika Verma places this novel beyond Vladimir Nabokov's *Lolita* and Bhagwati Charan Verma's *Chitralekha*, associating it with Acharya Rajneesh (Osho)'s idea of "from sexual union to samadhi." Osho holds that desire must not be suppressed but

transcended. Somdatt represses desire and becomes psychologically ill, whereas the indescribable satisfaction and wholeness that he finds after naturally acknowledging desire in Sumnima's "Manuvadah" is something his lifelong austerities had never given him.

A Comparative Paradigm of Arya and Kirat Worldviews

Conceptual Paradigm	Arya Culture (Somdatt/Puloma)	Kirat Culture (Sumnima/Bijua)
Epistemology	Grounded in the Vedas, Upanishads, scriptures and the pursuit of liberation	Closeness to nature, experience and a this-worldly philosophy of life
Attitude to the Body (Body Politics)	The body is transient, a pit of sin and an instrument to be repressed	The body is real, a celebration and the fundamental medium of joy
Sexuality	Ritual for procreation (putreshti), devoid of desire	A natural, innocent, loving and pleasurable need
Relationship with Nature (Ecological Stance)	To subdue nature and attain spiritual victory	To accept the laws of nature and live in accord with them
Religious Practices (Rituals)	Gayatri recitation, the five-fire austerity, celibacy and control of the senses	Spontaneity, sacrificial practices, material satisfaction and respect for the maternal principle
Language and Communication (Sociolinguistics)	Sanskritised, artificial, divine-language register, lofty idealism	Maternal, vernacular, realistic diction full of feeling

8. Ethnic Consciousness, the Arya–Kirat Conflict and the Ethics of Seeing the "Other"

Bhanubhakta Sharma Kandel regards *Sumnima* not merely as a Freudian narrative but as an important text of ethnic consciousness, cultural plurality, language, food, religion, customary life and minority experience. This perspective is evident in the novel's childhood conversations. A cow is "mother" and inviolable for one community, but food for another; the rules governing maternal and paternal descent differ; nakedness and clothing carry different meanings; religious institutions differ; nature, gods, diet and sexual conduct acquire different cultural significances. The author does not fix these distinctions into a formula in which "one is right, the other wrong." Somdatt certainly begins with a one-sided belief in superiority, but the story progressively dismantles his certainties.

Hariprasad Silwal's sociological study sees, amid the contrasting structures of Arya and non-Arya societies, values and environments, an emergent consciousness of an age moving towards reconciliation. The epilogue provides

the principal basis for this conclusion. The Brahmin hermitage disappears into nature, but Brahmin blood mingles with the Kirati community. The symbolism is clear: isolationist purity cannot endure; living cultures continue to change through mixture, marriage, remembrance and forgetting.

Nevertheless, modern criticism raises an uncomfortable question: does the novel itself sometimes imprison the Kirati community within fixed metaphors of "nature," "body" and "earth," and Brahmins within those of "soul," "scripture" and "sky"? This is a necessary critical caution. Such cultural dualisms are powerful literary devices, but actual communities are more varied and complex. If readers conclude that "Kirati = exclusively materialist" or "Brahmin = exclusively spiritual," the work's critique of culture will itself be transformed back into stereotype.

The novel partially escapes this danger. Sumnima possesses moral judgement and foresight; Somdatt is not a machine devoid of feeling; the next generation embodies biological and cultural intermixture. The final blessing's insistence that "both should understand their respective paths" expresses a principle of cultural dialogue. The finest reading of the work is therefore not ethnic essentialism but an education in seeing the "other" as human.

Deconstructing Cultural Hegemony

One of the most significant dimensions of *Sumnima* is its challenge to cultural hegemony. According to Antonio Gramsci's conception, a dominant group (the Aryas) imposes its worldview as universal truth. In the society portrayed, Arya-Brahmin culture regards itself as superior and Kirat-Bhil culture as "barbaric" or "uncultivated." Somdatt repeatedly addresses Sumnima as an "uncultivated girl" and describes her community's way of life as "bestial conduct." In the pride of his knowledge, he assumes that his culture is supreme.

However, drawing on Jacques Derrida's concept of deconstruction, Koirala reverses this hierarchy. As the novel unfolds, it becomes evident that Somdatt's supposedly "superior" knowledge and severe austerities make him disturbed, angry and dissatisfied. When he goes to Bijua in the Kirat village to beg for help in begetting a child, Bijua tells him: "Your mind has become corrupted! You tried to kill it through austerity! ... The body is not a machine, not an intermediary, not even an instrument. It is itself the end, the goal."

Ultimately Somdatt, defeated by his vow of celibacy, must seek Sumnima's refuge at Manuvadah. Here the hegemonic facade of Arya culture falls away. Koirala demonstrates that no culture becomes superior merely because a particular group practises it; natural reality and humanity are of the highest importance. The union of Arya and Kirat blood at the novel's end—the marriage of Somdatt's son to Sumnima's daughter—is a form of deconstruction in which the lineage of the dominant culture merges with that of the marginalised one.

The Kirat Controversy and Social Criticism

Although *Sumnima* is a singular jewel of Nepali literature, it has also generated controversy among followers of the Kirat religion. Some critics within the Kirat community allege that Sumnima and Parohang are revered deities of their faith, and that B. P. Koirala insulted them by representing them as ordinary human beings and placing them in sexual contexts.

From the standpoint of literary criticism and textual analysis, however, B. P. Koirala has not portrayed Sumnima as weak, insignificant or negative. Instead, she emerges throughout the novel as more rational, humane, compassionate and natural than the Arya man Somdatt. By the end of the intellectual struggle, Kirat culture is presented as life-giving and grounded in reality.

When, in the novel's epilogue, Somdatt's Arya son and Sumnima's Kirati daughter fall in love and enter into a *gandharva* marriage, their union amid the unbroken flow of the Koshi River brings forth a new generation that represents Nepal's true identity. This message offers a humane and syncretic resolution through assimilation and cultural synthesis to the controversy surrounding the novel. The merging of a drop of Arya blood into the great ocean of Kirati blood is, in effect, a realistic and far-sighted portrayal of Nepal's diverse demography.

9. Nature, Rivers, Forests and Ecological Meaning

Nature is the third major character in Sumnima. The Kaushiki River is not merely a backdrop; it symbolises time, change, the body, memory and the impermanence of civilisation. Characters are born, love, practise austerities and die; hermitages are built and disappear; yet the river continues to flow. In the closing sentences, the Kosi's uninterrupted course and immense stillness expose the limits of humanity's cultural claims.

For Somdatt, the forest is initially a site of ascetic discipline—a place where nature must be brought under control. For Sumnima, the same forest is home: a natural setting for movement, food, the body, play and love. The same natural world assumes different meanings when viewed through two cultures. Gradually, nature reabsorbs Somdatt's rigid construction. The hermitage collapses, becomes overgrown with thickets and loses its visible traces. This is not merely a romantic tableau of the "victory of nature"; it reveals the transience of memory and claims to power.

An ecofeminist reading identifies the parallel subordination of women and nature. Somdatt's patriarchal, scripturally grounded outlook turns both the body and nature into instruments; Sumnima restores the intrinsic worth of body and earth. Yet one limitation of this reading must be remembered: to make woman the "natural representative" of nature may itself reproduce a patriarchal stereotype. The novel becomes more valuable precisely when Sumnima emerges not simply as an embodied force of nature, but as a thoughtful agent capable of making decisions.

The rhythm of the river is effective in the language of the Maithili translation as well. In descriptive passages, extended sentences, onomatopoeic expressions, greenery, shami trees, sand, wind, water and the murmur or roar of the Kosi make the target text both visual and aural. Nature thus determines not only the subject matter but also the rhythmic character of the style.

Further Considerations: Natural Law, Violence and the Relationship between Woman and Nature

In this novel, Somdatt symbolises patriarchy and culture. He attempts to control nature (Sumnima), dismissing it as a "pit of sin," "hell" or "poison." For Somdatt, nature is something that must be conquered. Sumnima, by contrast, belongs wholly to nature. She is at one with the Kaushiki River, the forest birds, the flowers of the laligurans and the waters of Manuvadah. When a hawk attacks a pigeon, Somdatt tries to rescue the pigeon and advocates non-violence. Sumnima, however, explains that the hawk's taking its food is part of the natural order and that disrupting nature's arrangement in the name of religion may itself constitute a greater violence.

Puloma's character offers a tragic example for ecofeminist analysis. Under patriarchy, she suppresses her womanhood and natural desires. When she recognises Somdatt's emptiness, the rebellious woman within her awakens, and she challenges him by standing naked before him. Koirala makes clear that human beings can never become whole by separating themselves from nature or by repressing it.

10. Narrative Craft, Mythic Time and Symbolic Structure

The work begins as a story from "long ago," evoking the Puranas for a contemporary reader. This mythic distance frees the author from a precisely defined historical period and places cultural archetypes—the Brahmin hermitage, the Kirati settlement, the river, the forest and ascetic practice—on a symbolic plane. The memory of Vishvamitra, the mound where the hermitage stood, Vedic rites and Kirati oral traditions deliberately blur the boundaries between history and myth.

The mythic framework gives the narrative a transhistorical quality; nevertheless, the writer raises distinctly modern questions concerning ethnic superiority, nationhood, the body, women, marriage and social intermixture. Modernity beneath the covering of antiquity is one of the work's major formal achievements. In reading an apparently "ancient tale," the reader begins to question the rigid boundaries of contemporary society.

Prominent symbols include the shami tree, the hermitage, river, wind, earth, loincloth and sacred thread, the naked body and blood. The shami tree becomes a witness to love across generations; the hermitage signifies constructed culture and discipline; the river, change; the wind, the aspiration to rise above the self and the instability of that aspiration; earth, embodied life; the sacred thread and loincloth, cultural identity; nudity, a spontaneity before or beyond convention; and blood, biological intermixture and the dissolution of cultural purity.

The narrator repeatedly poses direct philosophical questions, particularly in the second chapter. Judged by a rigid modern injunction to "show rather than tell," these moments might appear to be essayistic intrusions. Yet the work is a philosophical-psychological novel, and these interventions fulfil a structural purpose. Weakness arises only when the questions become detached from the characters' experience. In Sumnima, most of them arise from psychological crises unfolding at that very moment, and their impact is therefore sustained.

II. The Linguistic Beauty of the Maithili Adaptation: Folk Rhythm, Register and the Music of Sentences

The clearest achievement of Vrishesh Chandra Lal as a translator is the living rhythm of the target language. In his foreword, Pradip Giri specifically cites words such as "patar-sutta," "ghonghauj," "asgare," "chakuait," "bhokasi parait kanait," "tamsa kae," "munh-jhappa" and "latta" as examples of expressions that lend the translation a distinctively Maithili flavour. Reading the target text confirms this observation. The dialogue does not sound bookish: it belongs to particular characters. Sumnima's speech is especially marked by playfulness, intimacy, local idiom and a direct awareness of the body.

The contrast between linguistic registers is an important instrument of the translation. Somdatt's sentences make greater use of Sanskrit-derived terms such as "udatta," "danamaya sambandha," "dvija dharma," "brahmacharya," "tapasya," "kartavya," "atma" and "kshetrapati"; Sumnima's language relies more on immediate vernacular words such as "ton," "yava," "may," "bap," "latta," "mati," "hava" and "chhuae." Even without the narrator's commentary, the reader can hear the cultural distance between the characters. Translation here recreates not merely "meaning" but a social voice.

In descriptive passages, the movement of Maithili verbs—"dekhait rahal," "bila geli," "satia gel," "nihara it," "bauait," "pasari jait"—animates the scene. Many sentences are long, but the chain of verbs sustains their rhythm. Sound imitation and sensory vocabulary are particularly effective in the descriptions of nature.

Another notable feature is the level of address. In exchanges between Sumnima and Somdatt during childhood, intimate or informal pronouns challenge cultural distance; Somdatt's scriptural formality and Sumnima's direct "re" reveal different standards of social decorum. Maithili possesses an elaborate system of pronominal respect and honorific distinction, making such choices exceptionally important for characterisation.

Nevertheless, an excess of Sanskrit-derived vocabulary can occasionally impede the reader's natural progress. This is not necessarily a fault of the translator alone: Somdatt's scriptural register may demand such diction. From the standpoint of the target reader, a short glossary of rare Vedic and philosophical terms would improve accessibility in a future edition without erasing the distinctions between registers.

Sociolinguistics and Identity

Language in the novel is not merely a medium of dialogue. It marks the characters' social, cultural, psychological and ideological identities. Vrishesh Chandra Lal's Maithili adaptation preserves this linguistic conflict with considerable skill.

In a representative scene, Somdatt calls his mother "mata" in the "language of the gods." Sumnima responds with a pointed question:

"Well, if you are a human being, why don't you speak in the language of human beings? A human being should not adopt the ways of the gods. A human being should remain human, Somdatt!"

"I cannot understand any of what you say, Somdatt! But I do understand this: it is not good for a human being to try to become a god. That is not a human being's duty. One should live according to one's own speech and ways. The moment anyone seeks to live as a god, that person will no longer remain human."

In this exchange, the opposition between "mata" (Sanskrit-derived, associated with divine language and expressive of distance) and "may" (vernacular, expressive of intimacy) symbolically encompasses the entire ideological architecture of the novel: artificial divinisation versus spontaneous humanity. It is worth noting that, in rendering this passage into Maithili, the translator faced the challenge of recreating the same linguistic and cultural hierarchy—the language of gods versus the language of ordinary people—within Maithili's own vocabulary. He succeeds in doing so.

Sumnima's vernacular speech is realistic, unvarnished and filled with human warmth; Somdatt's language becomes theoretical, scriptural and increasingly escapist in relation to lived reality. From a sociolinguistic perspective, language can construct power and hierarchy. In this narrative, the tension between everyday speech and divine language comes to signify social intimacy as against cultural distance.

Comparative Table of Linguistic Features

Linguistic Feature	Somdatt's Communicative Style (Arya)	Sumnima's Communicative Style (Kirat)
Type of Vocabulary	Sanskritised, formal and otherworldly ("mata," "Kapila mata," "atma-hanta")	Realistic, idiomatic and maternal ("may," "manuva," "babu")
Nature of Address	Idealistic and distancing ("O golden-faced maiden!" "Uncultured maiden!")	Intimate, direct and emotional ("Hey, patar-sutta!" "Somdatt!")
Emotional Expression	Repressed, concealed beneath an appearance of knowledge, devoid of	Unrestrained, playful and ironic ("How long will the Brahmins keep

	warmth	nursing their bile?")
Sociological Function of Language	Attempts to establish hierarchy and religious superiority	Seeks to establish equality, natural reality and humanity

12. Translation Theory: How Should We Read the Maithili Adaptation of Sumnima?

In his translator's note, Lal acknowledges the importance of sense-based translation (bhavanuvad) and the need for communicative fluency. This acknowledgement is particularly useful from the standpoint of translation theory, since the strategies observable in the target text substantiate it. The following theoretical approaches clarify the nature of his translation.

Literary Translation as a Creative Act

In his foreword, Pradip Giri advances an important proposition about translation: in some respects, literary translation is more creative than original writing. As an example, he cites Omar Khayyam's Rubaiyat, whose worldwide renown owes much to Edward FitzGerald's translation. This raises a central question in translation studies: is a translation merely the servant of its original, or can it become an independent creative work in its own right? Giri's proposition supports the second position.

Two Essential Qualities of a Translator

According to Giri, a successful translator must possess two indispensable qualities: first, the ability to understand the original work's inner meaning—its intention and spirit—and, second, a deep assimilation of the grace and beauty of the target language. Vrishesh Chandra Lal possesses both. As a follower of B. P. Koirala's political and intellectual legacy, he is familiar with the spirit of the original work; and because Maithili is his mother tongue, learned "in his mother's womb," his command of the target language comes naturally. Dr Shephalika Verma identifies this quality as bhavanuvad—meaning-centred translation sustained by an uninterrupted flow of communication—which she considers distinctly superior to word-for-word translation.

(a) Nida: Formal versus Dynamic Equivalence. In 1964, Eugene Nida drew a distinction between formal correspondence and dynamic equivalence. Dynamic equivalence seeks to produce a natural, comparable effect upon the target reader. The Maithili adaptation of Sumnima appears to favour the naturalness of the target language over strict word-for-word correspondence. Expressions such as "patar-sutta," Maithili verbal structures, forms of address and vernacular idioms suggest dynamic equivalence at work. The translator retains the cultural narrative of the source while reorganising its emotional pulse for the ear of a Maithili reader.

(b) Newmark: Semantic and Communicative Translation. Peter Newmark's semantic translation remains close to the source text's nuances of meaning and style, whereas communicative translation gives priority to clarity and

reception by the target reader. This adaptation balances the two. Vedic terms, rituals, Kirati names and vocabulary associated with the hermitage indicate a semantic orientation; dialogue, domestic idiom and effortlessly expressed emotional situations reveal a communicative one. Such a mixed strategy is appropriate to literary translation: communication alone can erase the source's cultural strangeness, while exclusive fidelity to its linguistic forms can make the target prose stiff.

(c) Venuti: Domestication and the Preservation of Foreignness. In Lawrence Venuti's terminology, the translator engages simultaneously in "domestication" and the preservation of "foreignness." Maithili idioms, Madheshi vernacular words and familiar sentence rhythms domesticate the narrative: the text finds a home within Maithili. Yet "Kirati," "Kaushiki," "yajna," "brahmacharya," "Bhill," cultural rites and the central conflict are not dissolved into local Maithili substitutes. These retained features preserve an element of foreignness. Through this double strategy, the text neither loses its Nepali cultural identity altogether nor remains alien in its target language.

(d) Catford: Structural Shifts in Translation. Between Nepali and Maithili—closely related languages with distinct grammatical and social systems—shifts in word order, pronouns, case markers, verbs, honorifics, idioms and lexical choices are unavoidable. Maithili verbal forms such as "kaelak," "kahalaki," "bhelaik," "rahal" and "chhali," together with the system of address in the target text, exemplify the accommodation of source-language structures to target-language grammar. Without the complete source text, it is impossible to establish a definitive inventory of specific shifts. Nevertheless, the target text clearly takes on an independent Maithili grammatical form rather than mechanically reproducing Nepali constructions.

(e) Skopos: The Purpose of Translation. The publisher's material makes clear that the aim is not only to make a novel available but also to establish B. P. Koirala's work among Maithili readers and deepen multilingual literary dialogue in Nepal. According to Skopos theory, the translator's strategies are connected with the intended function of the translation. From this perspective, the adoption of Maithili forms, vernacular vocabulary and readability is not incidental; it belongs to the translator's social purpose.

(f) Bassnett and the Cultural Turn. Susan Bassnett's approach to translation studies moves beyond linguistic equivalence to emphasise culture, power, history and literary systems. This perspective makes the Maithili Sumnima particularly significant: it transfers a major Nepali writer into another extensive mother-tongue literary world within Nepal. Translation thus becomes a cultural redistribution. Which works are available in which languages, and which readers are allowed to participate in a national literature, are questions intimately connected with power.

(g) Toury: Norms of the Target Culture. Gideon Toury's descriptive approach regards translation as a practice that takes place within the "norms" of the target culture. This text accommodates both literary refinement and the sweetness of spoken Maithili. It is neither a dry, excessively standardised

Maithili nor a rendering confined to a single local dialect. Instead, it develops a literary middle register for a broad Maithili readership.

Considered together, these theories suggest that Vrishesh Chandra Lal's strategy is oriented towards the communication of feeling, actively employs the target language and nevertheless preserves distinctive cultural residues. His voice as a translator is perceptible, but does not overpower the author's story.

Creative Transformation at the Level of Words

Lal's rendering of the Nepali words "dublo/patlo" as the Maithili "patar-sutta," and "roer" as "bhokasi parait kanait," demonstrates a high degree of creativity in translation. Furthermore, his precise use of distinctive Maithili verbal forms—such as "kahalkaik," "chhalaiki," "bajali" and "delkhin"—brings the characters' emotional states and gender distinctions vividly to life in Maithili.

13. The Achievements of Sense-Based Translation and Its Possible Risks

The principal advantage of bhavanuvad, or sense-based translation, is that the characters' emotions remain alive in the target language. Had Sumnima's lively speech retained the source language's sentence structure unchanged, it might have sounded artificial in Maithili. The translator avoids this danger by employing vernacular vocabulary and natural dialogue. Love, embarrassment, attachment, anger, agitation, maternal affection and irony are communicated with ease in the target text.

A second advantage is cultural proximity. The cultural regions of Mithila and Nepal have historically remained in contact; Vedic vocabulary, the cultural meanings of rivers and forests, and familial forms of address are not wholly unfamiliar to a Maithili reader. The translation draws upon this shared cultural capital.

The risk of sense-based translation, however, is "over-domestication." If highly localised target-language vocabulary obscures the distinctiveness of the source community, a reader may mistake the Kirati world for an extension of a Mithila village. In this edition, the preservation of most cultural names and symbols contains that risk, but it remains important to critical reading. In particular, the paratext's praise of "Madheshi words" itself signals a deliberate intensification of the target culture's flavour.

A second risk concerns the balance of registers in philosophical terminology. Somdatt's Sanskritised language suits his character, but excessive Sanskritisation may at times distance him so radically from Sumnima's accessible world that the ideological opposition hardens into a linguistic stereotype. A carefully edited edition could retain the contrasting registers while adding brief explanatory notes for rare terms.

A third risk is not the "invisibility" of the translator but the excessive visibility of the paratext. The publisher's note and forewords offer specific interpretations of nationhood, Madhesh, language politics and socialism that orient the reader along a particular interpretative path from the outset. Such

material is historically valuable, but a future edition would better serve literary readers by separating the "Translator's Note" and "Critical Introduction" into clearly marked sections, allowing readers to engage independently with the novel's multiplicity of meanings.

The Translator's Sociopolitical Agency and Cultural Geography

A translator does not work in a vacuum; translation entails ideological agency. Vrishesh Chandra Lal is himself a politician of Madheshi origin and a democratic socialist thinker. For a long period in Nepal, the Khas language enjoyed dominance under King Mahendra's Panchayat-era policy of "one king, one country, one language, one dress," with the result that other languages were marginalised.

The decision to translate Sumnima is itself a cultural and political statement. In his foreword, Pradip Giri places particular emphasis on the irony that King Mahendra, who suppressed Nepal's linguistic diversity through the slogan "one king, one country, one language, one dress," himself had an element of Maithil ancestry—yet neither Mithila nor Kirat culture received state recognition during the Panchayat period. In this context, the translation of B. P. Koirala's work by a politician of Madheshi origin carries profound meaning: it is itself an attempt to construct an alternative understanding of nationality.

The foreword also recalls that the characters in B. P. Koirala's novels range across Kathmandu, Darbhanga, Barahakshetra and Bhagalpur—across the broader cultural region encompassing Nepal, Mithila and Bihar—testifying to the breadth of Koirala's geographical and cultural vision. Viewed against Mithila's tradition of scholarship (Mandan Mishra, Vachaspati Mishra and Vidyapati) and the historical political and cultural decline of Mithila after the Shah dynasty, this translation becomes a meaningful attempt to nurture national and cultural solidarity through literature.

By referring to the element of Maithil ancestry in King Mahendra, Pradip Giri highlights a linguistic and cultural irony: notwithstanding the historical reality of mixed ancestry, Mithila and Kirat culture failed to receive the recognition due to them during the Panchayat period. The Maithili translation is therefore directly bound up with questions of nationality, language and cultural coexistence.

14. Limitations of the Work and Critical Objections

Serious criticism cannot consist solely of praise. Sumnima possesses considerable creative power, but certain questions remain open. First is the essentialism of its cultural binary. The opposition Brahmin = soul/sky/scripture and Kirat = body/earth/nature is effective as metaphor, but it simplifies the internal diversity of actual ethnic communities. Contemporary ethnic studies would require this opposition to be examined more intricately in relation to historical structures of power.

Second is the symbolic treatment of women. Sumnima becomes a powerful symbol of nature and the body, and Puloma embodies the suffering of

repression; nevertheless, the inner crisis of a male character remains the narrative's central philosophical axis. As a result, women sometimes appear to serve as instruments of a man's self-knowledge. The novel is not entirely free from this limitation, although Sumnima's independent moral choices and final social role strengthen her autonomy.

Third is the cultural translation of psychoanalysis. The novel's sexual and psychological structure is strikingly modern, but it is presented through Vedic and Kirati archetypes. Readers must not infer ethnographic facts about historical Kirati or Vedic societies from this mythic narrative. It is a literary metaphor, not a history textbook.

Fourth is the narrator's philosophical intervention. In this short novel, interrogative, essay-like passages occasionally interrupt the movement of the story. For many readers, they provide depth; for others, they impede narrative flow. This is a stylistic choice, not an unequivocal defect.

Fifth is the need for editorial work on the translated edition. Legacy fonts and encoding in the available PDF reduce the accessibility of the digital text. A future Unicode edition with searchable text, a glossary, an index of personal names, cultural notes and a clear account of the source edition would be invaluable. Such measures would increase both the longevity of this literary translation and its usefulness to researchers.

15. The Translator's Distinctive Achievements: Evaluation against Five Criteria

1. Readability — High. Maithili sentences flow naturally, and the dialogue is especially alive. Readers are not continually made conscious of reading a "translation."

2. Character Voice — Highly successful. The clear distinction between Somdatt's and Sumnima's registers establishes both character and philosophy. Puloma's speech also effectively expresses marital suffering, self-respect and anger.

3. Cultural Communication — Balanced. The Kirati and Vedic world of the source is preserved, while the language feels familiar to Maithili readers. Vernacular vocabulary increases the target culture's sense of proximity.

4. Aesthetic Re-creation — Successful. Descriptions of nature, bodily sensation, emotional dialogue and the rhythm of the epilogue produce a literary effect in Maithili. Pradip Giri's observation that the translation reads "like an original" captures this achievement: its language acquires a literary life of its own.

5. Research Value — Moderate to high, although editorial improvements are required. The text, foreword and publishing material are valuable; a future critical Unicode edition with word meanings, source references, translator's notes and a page index would be especially helpful for research.

16. Overall Literary Judgement

Sumnima, written by Vishweshwar Prasad Koirala, is not merely a storybook but an ideological battleground between Eastern and Western

philosophies. Through Somdatt, the novel exposes the hollowness of spiritual hypocrisy, cultural dominance and repressed sexual attitudes; through Sumnima, it accords the highest value to nature, humanity and the genuine pleasures of life.

The fundamental strength of Sumnima lies in its questions, not its answers. It asks whether a human being can be redeemed by defeating the body; whether a culture destroys life in its efforts to preserve its own purity; whether love possesses a moral truth beyond ethnic boundaries, religion, patrilineage and scripture; whether nature opposes civilisation or remains the original memory that continually makes civilisation more humane; and, most importantly, whether we can learn something from the "other" instead of trying to reform them.

The work's answer is not linear. It would be easy to proclaim Somdatt's complete defeat and the complete triumph of Kirati life, but the epilogue disrupts this simplification. Sumnima herself teaches her daughter to understand the Brahmin young man's "flight"; although brought up in a Kirati household, the Brahmin youth turns towards memories of the hermitage. The two fall in love, yet their differences do not disappear. Instead, accommodation, sensitivity and mutual change create the possibility of living together. At this point, the novel becomes a work of pluralist humanism.

The Maithili adaptation gives this humanism an additional historical meaning. When a narrative that deconstructs cultural superiority moves from Nepali into Maithili, that very movement becomes a literary act against linguistic centralism. The strength of Vrishesh Chandra Lal's target text lies in its treatment of Maithili not merely as a vehicle but as a co-creative language. Through Maithili folk rhythms, forms of address, verbs, idioms and sensory vocabulary, Sumnima acquires a new linguistic body.

Judged according to translation theory, this adaptation successfully combines dynamic or effect-based equivalence, communicative fluency, selective domestication and preservation of cultural foreignness. The recreation of feeling, character voice and cultural tension takes precedence over literal correspondence. This accords with the translator's declared commitment to bhavanuvad. It would be academically inappropriate to pronounce a final judgement on fidelity without a direct line-by-line comparison with the source text. Nevertheless, the literary autonomy of the target text is unquestionably substantial.

Ultimately, Sumnima is a work whose plot may be understood on a first reading, but whose questions continue to unfold through repeated readings. Psychoanalysis offers one doorway; ethnic studies another; feminism a third; ecology a fourth; and translation studies a fifth. Entering through all these doorways, we encounter at the centre the "human being": neither pure soul nor merely body; neither tradition alone nor nature alone; neither merely an ethnic identity nor an individualistic desire. A human being comes into existence through relationships. From this perspective, Sumnima's enduring literary value lies less in its love story than in its philosophy of relationship.

The Symbolic Significance of the Final Lines

"Within the vast ocean of Kirati blood, a single drop no longer had any separate existence. The Koshi flowed unhindered, cutting through nature's immense silence."

These lines symbolise intermixture: claims to personal and ethnic purity cannot endure within the immense currents of nature. Living history advances through relationship, mixture and change.

17. Editorial Recommendations for Future Editions

Publish the entire text in Unicode Devanagari so that searching, quotation, e-book production and digital archiving become straightforward.

Add a glossary of rare Vedic, Kirati and regional expressions, approximately two to four pages long, without interrupting the original text's rhythm.

In a translator's note, briefly explain the source edition, textual policy, the treatment of names and terms, the selection of vernacular words and the principles of sense-based translation.

Place the critical introduction and political-cultural paratext in separate sections so that readers may first encounter the novel as an autonomous literary work.

For researchers, provide a chapter-by-chapter page guide, an index of personal names, an index of principal symbols and a selected bibliography of secondary works.

In a future comparative edition, print selected passages from the original Nepali and Maithili texts in facing columns. This would greatly enhance the academic value of the edition for translation studies.

Final Note

The lasting achievement of Sumnima is not that it declares the body victorious over the soul, or the Kirat over the Brahmin. Its enduring achievement is to dismantle the arrogance of purity and establish relationship, intermixture, compassion and mutual change as the future of humanity. The Maithili adaptation gives this insight a living linguistic body and its own vernacular rhythm.

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PART II / TOME VIII

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Fiction, Social Realism and the Maithili Public Sphere

Gajendra Thakur · English translations from original Maithili by the author himself · Videha

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STUDY 05 / NIT NAVAL

Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’

Arrangement of the Book

Twelve critical studies of short fiction, novels, literary sketches, discursive prose, poetry and narratives for children are presented in four interconnected parts.

Part One — Folk Life, Fiction and Social Resistance

Gaam-Ghar

Aadambar

Part Two — Society, Women’s Identity and the Novel

Gudari Ke Lal

Anathiya Kukur

Sujata

Sukanya

Parivar

Part Three — Literary Sketches, Power and Mythic Reconsideration

Delhi Ke Park

Yachak Ke Nahi

Maharani Kaikeyi

Part Four — The Folk Currents of Song and Children’s Imagination

Kavya Sarita

Swarna Kamal

General Perspective

Nand’s Creative Practice and the Maithili Social Imagination

The creative world of Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’ cannot be contained within a single genre, narrative technique or social question. Beginning with the fictional worlds of Gaam-Ghar and Aadambar, and extending through Gudari Ke Laal, Anathiya Kukur, Sujata, Sukanya and Parivar, his prose reflects upon equality, the reconstitution of family life, women’s dignity and the many forms of social justice. In Delhi Ke Park and Yachak Ke Nahi, discussion, memory and social satire assume different forms. Maharani Kaikeyi constructs a counter-position to the accepted moral judgement of a familiar narrative; Kavya Sarita opens up a broad terrain of song and folk melody; and Swarna-Kamal brings children’s imagination, folktale and a sense of justice into a single imaginative framework.

Running through this diversity is a central tension between the unequal organisation of society and individual moral judgement. Village life is not merely an idyllic recollection here. Cultivation, unpaid compulsory labour, memorial feasts, caste, dowry, property disputes, bureaucratic structures and the dignity of public office all appear, in varying degrees, as forms of social power. Impelled by a reformist commitment, the storyteller sometimes advances an explicit argument and at other times demonstrates its consequences through the everyday conduct of characters. The tension between these two modes provides a basis for understanding both the strengths and the limitations of his literary craft.

In the social narratives addressed to mature readers, the interrelationships of class and caste frequently emerge through satire, dialogue and public events. In Gudari Ke Laal, the experience of a labouring family and questions of educational justice come into conflict with feudal dominance. Anathiya Kukur brings the differing mentalities of village and city into relation. Sujata and Sukanya consider women's right to make decisions within institutional circumstances shaped by marriage, widowhood, family and the workplace. Parivar seeks the meaning of a shared life through memory. These works enter into conversation with one another through their social concerns, although each possesses a distinct artistic form and configuration of characters.

Nand's social consciousness is active not only in identifying problems but also in imagining solutions. He regards education as a route to dignity and opportunity, justice as a public value, women's self-determination as a moral necessity, and familial cooperation as a social force. Yet literary criticism must also ask how naturally these idealistic solutions emerge from the narrative's internal development. When a protagonist or moral spokesman effortlessly unties a complex social knot, how much of the resistance encountered in lived experience does the story retain? To raise this question is not to disparage the writer's social purpose; it is to examine the artistic achievement of the work.

Delhi Ke Park and Yachak Ke Nahi mark a significant turn in this collection of criticism. In the former, a public garden becomes a forum for the exchange of experiences, allowing the memory of the village and the life of urban citizenship to enter into dialogue. In the latter, an expansion of the ethical meaning of 'supplication' challenges the distinction society creates between a beggar and a socially esteemed recipient of benefits. Here the clash of ideas, the rhythm of dialogue and the edge of satire become more important than the movement of plot.

Maharani Kaikeyi re-examines the established attribution of blame to a mythological character. The reinterpretation of myth becomes significant as literature when it places a familiar figure at the centre of new questions. Nevertheless, ethical reassessment and historical evidence are not identical; an alternative interpretation must be tested against reason and internal contradictions. For this reason, the work has been placed not among the social novels but in a separate part devoted to idea-centred prose.

As poetry, Kavya Sarita is a many-stranded current of invocations, devotional hymns, nachari songs, folk songs, social satire, awareness of the mother tongue and familial feeling. Swarna-Kamal offers another expression of this folk experience: a grandmother's storytelling, children's curiosity, a journey through the forest, marvels, and questions of justice and forgiveness. It is essential to recognise its independent generic status as a children's novel. The presence of instruction or moral exhortation in works for adults does not in itself make those works children's literature. Distinctions of subject, narrative perspective, complexity of experience and the age of the intended readership must be preserved.

The four parts of this book reveal these interrelationships between genre and ideas. Part One concentrates on shorter social narratives; Part Two on extended social novels; Part Three on literary sketches and idea-centred prose; and Part Four on poetry and children's narrative. Each discussion begins with the work's own characters, composition and linguistic techniques, before opening out into wider literary, social and comparative meanings. This arrangement does not pronounce the writer's varied works uniform; rather, it clarifies how a common ethical commitment operates within different creative methods.

Part One

Folk Life, Fiction and Social Resistance

Gaam-Ghar · Aadambar

Chapter 1

Gaam-Ghar

The Moral Economy of Village Life, Social Satire and Models of Narrative for Children

Nand Kumar Mishra's Gaam-Ghar (A Collection of Maithili Stories and Essays) draws upon rural experience to interrogate social inequality, extravagant expenditure on death rituals, caste hierarchy, women's participation in public life, marriage and dowry, religious ostentation, electoral self-interest and various forms of exploitation. The fifteen pieces in the collection do not belong to a single literary genre: the earlier stories remain close to rural realism and dialogue; in the middle section, social and political reflection enters the narrative structure; and in the concluding pieces, Unta Chaali, Ghodi Ke Anda and Sher Ke Aatank, parable, humour and animal allegory acquire greater prominence. This essay undertakes textual analysis on the basis of the original book's contents, preliminary statements, printed texts and underlying critical themes. In the comparative context of Maithili children's literature, the significance of this work does not lie simply in its being 'children's stories'; rather, the writer constructs a literary bridge from adult social satire to parables accessible to children. Nevertheless, lengthy didactic passages, limited psychological development of characters and an occasionally simplistic idealisation of solutions constitute artistic limitations. The historical discussion draws on a comparative

framework involving the Sahitya Akademi's publication records, lists of children's literature awards and policy documents concerning school reading in India.

Introduction: The Collection's Literary Position and the Questions of Criticism

The title Gaam-Ghar draws the reader into the familiar world of a particular place, but the concerns of the collection are not confined within the boundaries of the village. For the author, the village is a field of social experiment in which custom, prestige, money, familial expectations, religion, power and justice collide. He generates social questions out of events that appear ordinary on the surface: At what point does a feast held for the dead cease to express reverence and become a display of status? What meaning does the worship of a banyan tree acquire between environmental concern and religious orthodoxy? What are the actual obstacles to women's leadership in the village panchayat? How far apart are the language of democracy and the practice of power?

The work bears the subtitle 'A Collection of Maithili Stories and Essays'. To regard it as an exclusively children's story collection would therefore be a mistake of genre classification. Narrative episodes are combined with reflective prose; this mixture intensifies the author's social intervention, although at times the story itself becomes a vehicle for the essay. In the author's 'A Few Words', superstition in village life, caste discrimination, social malpractices and intrigue are identified as the work's creative concerns. In his opening message of goodwill, Narendra Jha discusses the stories' satirical quality, the social implications of Shankar Ke Khoj and the child-oriented character of the final two pieces. Read alongside the text, these two paratexts reveal the collection's internal organisation.

The purpose of this essay is not to decide whether every episode meets all the criteria of the modern short story. The central question, instead, is where the desire for social reform succeeds in taking the form of literary scene, dialogue and event, and where it remains an explicit declaration of ideas. The history of children's literature provides a comparative criterion for this assessment; it does not justify a mistaken generic classification of the entire work.

The Work and the Sequence of Its Contents

The cover prints the title Gaam-Ghar, identifies the genre as 'A Collection of Maithili Stories and Essays', and names 'Nand Kumar Mishra' as the author. The opening publication details mention Mrs Amal Devi and Mrs Shanta Bhushan (Bhikhanpur, Bhagalpur), while the printing credit names Asha Printing Press, Tilkamanjhi, Bhagalpur. The author's 'A Few Words' is dated 26 November 2004; this is the date of the author's note, not necessarily the book's year of publication. The back cover refers to the author's previously published Vidyarthi, dated 25 April 2004. It would therefore be inappropriate to infer a definitive year of publication for Gaam-Ghar from those dates.

The original table of contents lists fifteen pieces, extending from printed story-page 1 to page 99. Their sequence and page ranges are presented below.

This arrangement also makes clear that the final three pieces are particularly parabolic in character.

No.	Work	Printed Pages
1	Baba Ke Bhoj	1–7
2	Dabdabaael Aankhi	8–14
3	Bhor Ke Sapna	15–22
4	Bar Ke Gaachh	23–28
5	But Ke Saag	29–36
6	Shankar Ke Khoj	37–47
7	Fekani Mai	48–55
8	Kodh	56–63
9	Chakra-Chaali	64–69
10	Swabhiman	70–76
11	Loot-Tantra	77–81
12	Dand	82–86
13	Unta Chaali	87–90
14	Ghodi Ke Anda	91–94
15	Sher Ke Aatank	95–99

A Narrative-Centred Perspective: Village, Family, Religion and Power

In this collection the ‘village’ is not an unchanging or untroubled cultural unit. Expenditure increases through competition with neighbours; the farmer’s means of livelihood are consumed in displays of prestige; caste-based distance survives under the cover of religious observance; women seek entry into public decision-making; and politics poisons village relationships. The writer represents economic inequality not merely as a difference in income, but as an unequal distribution of status and authority in social conduct. From this perspective, the collection’s central concern may be called a ‘moral economy’: how society spends money, which expenditures it treats as marks of prestige, and upon whom the burden of such spending falls.

The narrator generally describes a social situation before recounting an incident, and then illustrates it through a family, a character or a conversation. The reader is thus immediately introduced to the issue. Yet this structure often becomes a pattern of narrative indication, development of the episode and a predetermined conclusion. Characters are left with little freedom of action. The result is a book accessible as a form of public education, but uneven in its achievement when measured against the demands of deeper psychological exploration.

Individual Textual Analyses of the Fifteen Pieces

‘Baba Ke Bhoj’: Death Rituals and Social Display

The story opens with news of Feku Baba’s death, and the village community’s response supplies its narrative background. From the beginning, indications are given of the deceased man’s family standing, resources and social prestige. In the closing section, the reader encounters the lavish organisation of a shraddha feast, its abundant dishes, the influx of outsiders, disorder and the dissipation of wealth. The contrast between outward splendour and underlying waste forms the centre of the story’s satire.

What matters is that the feast does not remain merely a family occasion: invisible social pressure determines its scale. The story asks whether expenditure incurred in imitation of others honours the dead or expresses the living family’s competition for prestige. The author’s direct commentary sometimes diminishes the subtlety of the implicit satire, but the descriptive scenes clearly expose the social psychology of pointless expenditure.

‘Dabdabaael Aankhi’: Memory, Generations and Changing Customs

The narrator introduces the episode by recalling familiar customs in the village of an earlier time. The comparison between relationships associated with Lal Bhaiya and changes in conduct forms the emotional foundation of the story. The tear-filled eyes of the title are not merely a decorative symbol of pathos; they indicate the moral distance between memory and the present. On one side is the remembrance of former intimacy and communal attachment; on the other, distrust and distress at new forms of social behaviour.

The writer’s narrative method is grounded in memory. The danger of idealising the past is present here: one cannot unconditionally accept that the earlier social order was itself egalitarian. Nevertheless, the story’s essential sensibility is that social change should be evaluated not only through outward conveniences or material advancement, but also through mutual respect and emotional responsibility.

‘Bhor Ke Sapna’: Caste, Worship and Imagined Social Equality

The piece begins by discussing the uncertain reliability of a dream seen at dawn. An episode involving the participation of the community in a village Brahm worship raises the problem of caste distance. The literary device of the ‘dream’ allows the writer to imagine a scene of equality that would encounter formidable barriers in waking social reality. The dream is therefore not an escape, but a counterfactual means of criticising the present.

Toward its close, the narrative points to cooperative community efforts by local people, including education and a reading room. This offers a positive vision of transformation, but the difficulties of putting it into practice are explored less fully. Here the author places a discussion of the problem beside a proposal for an ideal society.

'Bar Ke Gaachh': Folk Belief, Nature and Environmental Responsibility

The banyan tree is more than an ordinary plant within the narrative setting: it is a centre of religious vows, worship, shade, rest, the Barsait observance and village sociability. At first the writer describes the tree's social and religious uses; later the idea of conservation and collective participation emerges. Through this duality, the tree becomes not simply a religious symbol but a public space within everyday communal life.

One achievement of the story is that it does not reject tradition outright; instead, it seeks out its social and ecological usefulness. Its limitation is that a more sustained examination of the relationship between religious observance and the protection of trees would have strengthened the argument. Even so, the social scenes around the tree meaningfully recall the shared cultural geography of village life.

'But Ke Saag': Education, Marriage and a Woman's Choices

In this story, the central problem is the pressure to marry exerted upon a young woman who wants to continue her studies. Her mother's wishes, public opinion and the possibility of her education remaining unfinished are closely intertwined. Later episodes involving Shalini and the decision about marriage lead the reader from an ordinary domestic question to the larger issue of a woman's self-determination and dignity.

The title 'But Ke Saag' has an appeal rooted in its rural domestic familiarity, but the story's actual debate centres on education, the timing of marriage and the right to decide. The writer criticises traditions hostile to education. From a critical perspective, the complexity of women's experience and their independent personhood might have been developed further had the character been given greater room for inward reflection. The case for change is clear, but the breadth of perspective remains limited.

'Shankar Ke Khoj': From Mythological Narrative to Class and Political Questions

The work begins with the mythological episode of the churning of the ocean and proceeds to the figure of Shankar, who drinks the poison. It then turns towards the poisons of modern society: corruption, plunder, economic inequality, injustice at work, the exploitation of labourers and the disorders of democratic institutions. Here Shankar is not an inert divine solution but a demand for collective moral courage and self-examination.

The work's form approaches modern essayistic satire. The mythological opening activates the reader's memory, but the widening discussion in the middle and final sections weakens its concentration as a short narrative. Nevertheless, the writer's important proposition is that change calls not simply for an external saviour but for responsible individuals acting within society. In this piece, a concern with national social life beyond the boundaries of the village is most clearly expressed.

‘Fekani Mai’: Women’s Leadership and the Democratic Possibilities of the Panchayat

The story opens with a portrayal of Fekani Mai’s poverty, labour and conduct within ordinary social life. Against the background of domestic deprivation and difficulty in earning a living, the idea arises of advancing her towards leadership in the village panchayat. The story does not leave Fekani Mai as an object of pity; it transforms the trust she commands, her familiarity to local people and community support into sources of political strength. Educated and ordinary villagers together wish to bring a neglected woman into public office.

The particular significance of this episode lies in its attempt to give the language of democracy concrete form within a living village community. Yet the struggle becomes relatively straightforward: obstacles embedded in the structure of power, contradictions of caste and class, the complexities of electoral competition and the administrative questions that follow election are not developed in detail. Even so, this is one of the collection’s principal affirmative stories, because a change in women’s social position occupies its centre.

‘Kodh’: Dowry, Debt and the Erosion of Family Ethics

The story concerns preparations for a marriage and the economic expectations of a family. Through Kamlesh, the proposed marriage, an auspicious occasion and financial pressure, the social harm caused by dowry comes into view. Dowry is represented not merely as the exchange of material goods, but as an affront to trust and a devaluation of relationships. ‘Kodh’, or ‘leprosy’, is an ethical metaphor in the title: it is social greed rather than a person that is marked out as diseased.

The story conveys how the dignity of marriage is corrupted by the logic of transactions. The experience would have acquired greater density if the characters’ embarrassment, fear and inner conflict arising from financial compulsion had received more attention than the didactic conclusion. Nevertheless, the argument against dowry is tied to concrete circumstances of rural life.

‘Chakra-Chaali’: Rural Politics and Community Division

At the outset the writer distinguishes the politics of the capital from the politics of village life. Factionalism, mutual hostility, competing rituals and the politics of collective celebrations provide the principal material for this essayistic narrative. Through an episode involving the organisation of a navah religious observance in 1999, the writer shows that communal worship, too, can become a contest for prestige and group dominance.

The narrator recounts an incident in which his own community suffered humiliation; this autobiographical register makes the criticism more subjective, but also more immediate. One limitation of Chakra-Chaali is that the different aspects of local struggles for power do not emerge with equal complexity; the author’s moral position remains unmistakable. Nevertheless,

the work shows that social disintegration is not merely a consequence of 'high politics'; it operates in the everyday conduct of village life as well.

'Swabhiman': The Dignity of the Ordinary Citizen versus the Authority of High Office

The piece begins as a conversation with an acquaintance. Inequalities in the conduct of officials, police officers, members of the medical profession and ordinary individuals enter the narrative. An incident involving Nishad Babu elucidates the idea of self-respect: honour does not arise merely from rank, property or obedience to commands issued by others, but from the experience of one's own dignity.

The oral mode of narration is effective here: the narrator recounts an incident and directs the reader's attention towards the self-respect of a figure resembling a protagonist. Although the solution depends upon the generous and resolute conduct of one particular individual, the work intervenes firmly on behalf of the dignity of ordinary people.

'Loot-Tantra': The Linguistic Irony of Democracy

The title itself constitutes sharp satire: 'Loot-Tantra' ('rule by plunder') in place of 'Lok-Tantra' ('democracy') expresses the distance between power and the people's rights. Beginning with a recollection of Gandhian independence, the work criticises voting practices, crime, corruption, arbitrary administration and caste-based political division. Its structure is relatively explicitly essayistic: it contains less plot and a more sustained sequence of ethical and political argument.

The writer regards the vote as more than a formal entitlement: it is an instrument of public accountability. The work is important as evidence of the political consciousness of its time; nevertheless, political claims should be read as the writer's contemporary critical perspective rather than as established historical facts. Its language is one of vehement moral dissent, not of a balanced political survey.

'Dand': The Display of Religious Merit and Moral Justice

Through the contrasting dispositions of Sonu Jha and Monu Jha, the story raises the distinction between the external performance of religion and genuine compassion. One character is straightforward, helpful and generous; the other combines religious ostentation with self-centred conduct. At the end, the idea of 'punishment' signifies not a narrative of direct retaliation but an awareness of moral and spiritual consequences.

The arrangement of two contrasting characters is a familiar device of the folk parable, in which human complexity is reduced in order to make the underlying lesson clear. To an extent the piece may be regarded as close to the moral narrative suitable for children; its conception of justice, however, is intertwined with religious and ethical beliefs rather than with questions of scientific verification.

‘Unta Chaali’: Deception, a Pundit’s Simplicity and a Cautionary Parable

The story begins by introducing a pundit who is learned but ingenuous in practical affairs. Some swindlers exploit his trusting disposition, social standing and momentary lack of caution. The sequence of events exposes the difference between reputed intelligence and genuine practical judgement. The title Unta Chaali suggests both dishonest manoeuvring and a reversal of circumstances.

Drawing upon a familiar motif of deception in folktales, the story offers both humour and a lesson in caution. Its attraction for young readers lies in the reversal of events. Yet the author simplifies both the social characterisation and the moral conclusion; it is more appropriate to regard such a work as an amusing piece of public instruction than as a direct document of social reality.

‘Ghodi Ke Anda’: Trading in an Impossible Object and the Fraud of Credulity

The story moves forward through the humorous interaction of a mischievous boy named Maturwa and an elderly man. The impossible notion of a ‘mare’s egg’ brings gullible belief into collision with cunning commercial intent. The reader knows from the beginning that such an egg cannot exist; rather than curiosity about ‘what will happen?’, the narrative arouses an interest in ‘how is trust exploited?’

Towards the end, the community discusses exposing the deceit and the theme of caution on the part of the buyer emerges. From the standpoint of children’s literature, this is one of the collection’s most natural stories: the plot is brief, its central object intriguing, the dialogue clear and the humour spontaneous. Nevertheless, the intensity of its satire and the language of punishment may occasionally require sensitive reconsideration in relation to a child’s imagination.

‘Sher Ke Aatank’: Despotic Power in an Animal Allegory

In a dense forest, relations between the lion and the other animals are determined by an imbalance of power. Terrorised by the oppressive lion, the creatures consider a collective remedy; the story proceeds to develop an allegory of elections, parties, voting and change of government. The animal setting engages the reader, but its political implications are directly connected with a critique of power struggles in adult society.

The story brings together the folk-tale fable and political satire with considerable success. Young readers can engage with the animal characters, while mature readers can discern a structural critique of corrupt leadership. The possibility that despotic power may return in another guise raises a difficult moral question: does replacing the ruler alone end exploitation, or is institutional vigilance also necessary? This open political implication gives the story a powerful position at the end of the collection.

Brief Quotations from the Original Text: Linguistic Evidence and Critical Significance

The quotations below follow the page numbers printed in the original book. Each is restricted to clearly legible wording at the relevant location; no reconstructed, conjectural or doubtful readings are quoted here. The observation following each quotation is a critical interpretation, not part of the original text.

1. *"We learned that Feku Baba had passed away." — 'Baba Ke Bhoj', p. 1*

A notice of death initiates a communal social drama; not an extraordinary event, but ordinary village news, opens the way to satire.

2. *"People say that a dream seen at dawn comes true, but I did not believe it." — 'Bhor Ke Sapna', p. 15*

The question of the dream's truth brings the narrator's scepticism and the inequalities of social reality into view at once.

3. *"But the banyan tree has a significance of its own." — 'Bar Ke Gaachh', p. 23*

This brief sentence contains the tree's communal significance in folk life, extending beyond its biological existence.

4. *"There was a pundit. He was an exceptionally learned scholar and also a practitioner of religious rituals." — 'Unta Chaali', p. 87*

The opening dramatic irony of the deception story centres on the difference between an individual's scholarship and practical judgement.

5. *"This is a mare's egg." — 'Ghodi Ke Anda', p. 91*

The humour of an impossible claim establishes the central relationship between belief and deception in the narrative.

6. *"There was a very large and dense forest." — 'Sher Ke Aatank', p. 95*

The creation of a folk-tale setting introduces the political animal allegory.

The quotations have deliberately been kept brief. The complete contexts are presented through interpretation rather than by reproducing extended passages of the source text. This maintains a clear distinction between the author's linguistic voice, references to printed pages and critical discussion.

Language, Orality, Narrative Craft and Aesthetic Sensibility

The collection's dominant style combines direct address with a linguistic rhythm close to everyday speech. Constructions such as 'I saw', 'although', 'but' and 'whereas' keep the narrator in conversation with the reader. Familiar proverbial assertions, the vocabulary of rural economic dealings, descriptions of feasting, panchayat elections and domestic courtyards combine to make local experience credible. Because of this accessibility, the stories never feel remote even when the social questions are complex.

Structurally, the relative proportions of incident, memory, domestic conversation and communal conduct vary across the first six or seven pieces. The dominance of the essay is apparent in Shankar Ke Khoj and Loot-Tantra; the sequence of events and ironic reversals occupy the centre in Unta Chaali and Ghodi Ke Anda; and Sher Ke Aatank conveys a political message through animal allegory. Rather than treating this variety as only a weakness, it may be read as a credible sign of the book's own generic designation as 'stories and essays'.

The moral pronouncements of the works frequently reduce the reader's freedom to discover meaning. Ambiguity of character, psychological conflict, symbols with multiple meanings and uncertain endings—the resources of modern narrative aesthetics—are employed only to a limited extent. Even so, the practical energy of the satire is remarkable: the writer builds a critique of social institutions from minor incidents and compels the reader in many stories to reflect upon human conduct.

The Work's Place in the History of Maithili Children's Literature: A Comparative Study

Folktale, Readership and the Question of Genre

In writing a history of children's literature, the first distinction to remember is that not every work which can be read to a child was necessarily written for children. Folk narratives, animal parables, moral tales and social satire are closely related, but differ in the age and experience of their readers, their language, narrative complexity and original purposes. Gaam-Ghar is a transitional collection in this sense. Baba Ke Bhoj, Kodh, Swabhiman and Loot-Tantra raise economic and institutional questions belonging to adult social life. The readily comprehensible humour and allegorical character of Unta Chaali, Ghodi Ke Anda and Sher Ke Aatank make them more accessible to young readers.

The opening message of goodwill in the published book confirms this distinction: it points to the child-oriented qualities of some of the concluding pieces, without seeking to label the whole book a collection for children. Its proper place in literary history is within Maithili social satire, as a narrative terrain from which forms of parable suitable for children emerge.

From Multilingual Reading for Children in the 1990s to Local Stories

The Sahitya Akademi's list of Maithili publications indicates that, from the 1990s onward, both original Maithili stories and translations from other languages were made available to child readers. Publication records include, for example, Sureshwar Jha's translation of Jayant Narlikar's science fiction as Antariksh Mein Visphot (1996); Uday Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa's translation of Rabindranath Ka Bal Sahitya (1997); a translation of Leelavati Bhagwat's Marathi story Jungle Mein Ek Raat (1998); and the original Maithili story selection Katha Kisalay, edited by Chandranath Mishra 'Amar' (1999). The list also includes O Baba: Ki Baua (translated by Govind Jha, 2000), from an Assamese story by Lakshminath Bezbarua.

These publication records support a limited but definite conclusion: science, translated folktales, Rabindranath Tagore's literature and original Maithili writing were being developed concurrently for young Maithili readers. Comparison with the final narratives in Gaam-Ghar shows that Mishra's child-accessible stories are connected less with science-based curiosity than with the traditions of folk parable, moral inquiry and social satire. The comparison rests on publication dates and genre classifications; this essay does not claim to offer a direct comparative reading of the complete texts of all the works cited above.

2010–2025: The Expansion of Recognised Genres in Children's Literature

The Sahitya Akademi's official list of Maithili Bal Sahitya Puraskar recipients for 2010–2025 demonstrates the generic diversity of children's literature. It records Taranand Viyogi's Ee Bhetal Tan Ki Bhetal (stories, 2010); Mayanath Jha's Jakar Nari Chatur Hoi (stories, 2011); Murlidhar Jha's Pilpilaha Gaachh (stories, 2012); Dhirendra Kumar Jha's Hamra Beech Vigyan (essays, 2013); Jivakant's Hamar Athanni Khasalai Van Me (poetry, 2014); Ramdev Jha's Hansani Paan Aa Bajanta Supari (novel, 2015); Amlendu Shekhar Pathak's Lalgaachhi (novel, 2017); Vaidyanath Jha's Khissa Sunu Bau (stories, 2018); and Rishi Vashishtha's Ee Phoolak Guldasta (stories, 2019).

The later entries include poetry by Siyaram Jha 'Saras' in 2020; poems by Anmol Jha in 2021; Virendra Jha's Udan-Chhu (stories, 2022); Akshay Anand 'Sunny's poetry collection Ol Katra, Jhol Katra (2023); Narayanji's Anar (2024); and Munni Kamat's Chukka (2025). This official roster establishes only that stories, poems, novels, biographies and scientific essays have become recognised fields of literary work for children. It would be inappropriate to regard an award list as the complete history of children's literature, the sole measure of quality or evidence that unlisted works do not exist.

Gaam-Ghar offers a distinctive bridge from an earlier social sensibility to this later institutional landscape: adult social reflection and child-accessible parable coexist in a single collection. Ghodi Ke Anda is readily suitable for young readers because of its humour, whereas the electoral allegory of Sher Ke Aatank may be more meaningful for an older age group or with the mediation of a teacher. Such a distinction should be understood not as a permanent rule about age categories but as a considered suggestion concerning the work's use by readers.

Mother Tongue, Illustration and Local Experience: Educational Criteria

The National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage (2022) emphasises stories and songs connected with local culture, reading materials in the mother tongue, selection of narratives appropriate to age, picture-supported reading and respect for diverse speech varieties. By these policy criteria, the familiar village language and folk parables of Gaam-Ghar could serve as useful material; its printed form, however, consists primarily of extended prose, not an illustrated book for beginning readers. Selected stories, assistance with difficult words, visual presentation, questions following

dialogue and editorial adaptation for different age groups might be needed for child readers.

For example, a short dramatic adaptation of Ghodi Ke Anda could help readers understand the distinction between rumour and evidence. Sher Ke Aatank could form a basis for discussion of democracy, majority rule and civic responsibility. Fekani Mai could make possible a discussion of gender equality and village government in the higher classes. These proposals should be understood as new educational uses, distinct from the meanings of the original works, and not as teaching devices devised by the author.

Overall Assessment: Achievements, Contradictions and Critical Limitations

The work's principal achievement lies in identifying social wrongs in accessible Maithili and converting them, through narrative situations, into matters for public debate. The prestige accorded to expenditure in Baba Ke Bhoj, the vision of eliminating caste divisions in Bhor Ke Sapna, the conflict between marriage and education in But Ke Saag, women's leadership in Fekani Mai, the critique of dowry in Kodh, the irony of democracy in Loot-Tantra and the symbolic representation of autocratic rule in Sher Ke Aatank form a sequence of related ethical questions. The writer's social commitment is a constant presence across these pieces.

A second achievement is the blending of genres. Short fiction, recollective narration, social essays, religious parables, folk humour and animal stories coexist within the collection. This variety permits different groups of readers to approach the book. In the final three pieces in particular, local conversation and customary humour comment indirectly on the social order.

The limitations are equally evident. At numerous points the narrator announces a conclusion before the event unfolds; consequently the autonomy of the characters is restricted and narrative suspense diminished. Solutions to social problems sometimes depend excessively on the goodwill of exemplary characters or on unanimous community agreement. Although women are represented sympathetically, their inner experiences receive relatively little fine-grained exploration. In political commentary, sharp satire at times overwhelms the consideration of multiple perspectives. For these reasons it is more accurate to describe the collection as a narrative intervention in society than as a work of theoretical narrative.

The local publication details, dedication, message of goodwill and intimate 'A Few Words' in the printed book testify to its cultural setting. The work is not simply a sum of separate stories; it is an organised expression of a writer's ethically engaged social consciousness. In determining its place in literary history, therefore, equal importance must be given to regional experience and artistic form.

Conclusion

Nand Kumar Mishra's Gaam-Ghar centres on a point in Mithila's social life at which tradition, a modern awareness of rights and communal ethics

remain in continuous negotiation. While retaining their local colour, the stories engage with social problems of national significance. The writer takes an unequivocal position against the suffering of others, waste, plunder, discrimination and injustice; this clarity invites readers in many passages to reflect directly upon the issues presented.

From the standpoint of children's literature, the collection's place must be determined with particular care. Gaam-Ghar as a whole is not children's literature, although it contains powerful elements of parable accessible to children. The discernment needed to recognise deception in Unta Chaali, the humorous impossibility of the claim in Ghodi Ke Anda, and the animal politics of Sher Ke Aatank offer distinct possibilities for children's reading, higher school classes and adult criticism. To regard Gaam-Ghar as a bridge between Maithili rural social satire and folk-based narrative forms for children is therefore a balanced literary assessment of its achievement.

Chapter 2

Aadambar

Folk Life, Social Hypocrisy and the Narrative Structure of Resistance

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Aadambar (2017) is a collection of twenty Maithili stories centred on questions of village society in Mithila, family relationships, the prestige attached to shraddha feasts, caste inequality, electoral politics, education, labour, property, religious belief and public morality. The title story reveals the psychology of social display; other stories, including 'Aarakshan', 'Loktantra', 'Etek Jaati Kiek?' and 'Rail-Yatra', take the form of debates about equality and institutional conduct. 'Begaar' portrays class dependence, 'Laash' the conflict between property and familial self-interest, 'Kavik Jingi' the social position of the creative writer, and 'Jaani Ka Besahab' the moral conflict between the accumulation of wealth and philanthropy. This study follows the sequence and page ranges of all twenty stories as given in the printed contents and undertakes separate textual analyses, an assessment of themes and techniques, an examination of linguistic form and critical limitations, and a generic comparison with the historical field of Maithili children's literature. While preserving the distinction between the source book's social fiction and literature consciously addressed to children and adolescents, the essay argues that Aadambar is distinguished by its initiation of public discussion in the vernacular on contentious issues. Its limitation lies in the excessive extension of direct moral instruction within some of the stories.

Introduction: The Irony of the Title and the Character of the Collection

The word 'aadambar' evokes outward display, a craving for prestige and ostentatious values divorced from actual conduct. The collection's title, however, goes beyond this immediate meaning. Reading the twenty stories makes the word a commentary upon internal contradictions within social institutions: occasions of religious observance become substitutes for compassion; elections lose their connection with justice; education confronts the uncertainties of employment; and the accumulation of wealth causes social responsibility to be forgotten. The fictional world is populated not primarily by privileged metropolitan protagonists, but by village farmers, teachers,

dependent labourers, impoverished families, political aspirants, poets, relatives and people engaged in village conversation.

Humour is frequently the surface layer of these stories; beneath it run insecurity, inequality, humiliation and the struggle for self-preservation. The satirical storyteller seeks to lead the reader towards a conclusion, but this raises a persistent question: is literary fiction merely a forum for debate, or can it also create an autonomous artistic experience through the distinctive circumstances of its characters' lives? Both the achievement and the limitation of the collection reside in this tension.

According to the book's printed publication details, the first edition appeared in 2017 from Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Uparadaha, Darbhanga, at a stated price of 150 rupees. Its story pages are numbered 1 to 160. Both the cover and the internal presentation identify the author as Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'. The introductory 'A Few Words' and 'Author's Note' are followed by a list of twenty stories with their printed page references. These details matter to the present criticism because they identify the work as an independent short-story collection, not a compilation of children's stories or a children's novel.

The Collection's Outline and Sequence of Stories

The primary text for this discussion is the printed 2017 edition of Aadambar. Story titles and opening pages have been checked against its contents; page references given where relevant refer to the printed story pages. Discussion of narrative substance emphasises the relationships among character, episode, dialogue, ending and narrative style. The object of textual analysis is not merely to repeat the author's purported 'message', but to examine narrative tension, authorial intervention, social circumstances and creative resolution.

Only short quotations that are clearly legible and can be confirmed verbatim have been used. Where the precise order of letters could not be established with certainty, the subject matter has been analysed through indirect description. An extended account of a story must therefore not be treated as a substitute for its original text. Videha's lists of books, children's literature, prose and parallel literary history furnish comparative references; the mere appearance of a book in a list does not prove that its full contents have been read. Accordingly, the comparative sections distinguish between different levels of evidence.

Sequence of Stories and Their Printed Page Ranges

No.	Story	Printed Pages
1	Aadambar	1–6
2	Ropal Gaachh Babur	7–15
3	Pashchatap	16–23
4	Ojha Lekhen Gaam Bataah	24–28

No.	Story	Printed Pages
5	Aarakshan	29–36
6	Loktantra	37–46
7	Rail-Yatra	47–52
8	Etek Jaati Kiek?	53–65
9	Laash	66–76
10	Heart Attack	77–84
11	Begaar	85–91
12	Pari-Katha	92–103
13	Kukuruk Naangari	104–113
14	Lati	114–123
15	Kavik Jingi	124–132
16	Udyan	133–137
17	Narak Ke Yatra	138–144
18	Sanket	145–150
19	Arajal Bhog	151–155
20	Jaani Ka Besahab	156–160

Source: Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’, Aadambar, sequence of stories. The final page of each story has been determined from the beginning of the next and from the last story page, 160.

The Collection’s Narrative Outlook: Folk Life, Dialogue and Satire

The fictional territory of Aadambar may be understood through three interwoven spheres. The first encompasses family and social conduct in the village, giving rise to questions of shraddha, food, prestige, illness, kinship, marriage and death. The second consists of public institutions, bringing in experiences of reservation policy, elections, caste, education, rail travel and salaried occupations. The third is the sphere of parable and moral imagination, in which fairy tales, journeys through hell, the poet’s condition and arguments about wealth and religious merit become subjects of debate. These divisions are not rigid, since power exists within the family and private interest within public arrangements.

The author places considerable emphasis on dialogue. Characters frequently raise a question, another voice offers a counterargument, and the incident gradually turns into an exchange of ideas. This technique has a social advantage: caste, exploitation, poverty and religious belief do not remain distant from the reader. It also carries an artistic risk: the character’s individual voice at times seems to dissolve into the author’s direct discourse. The story becomes more effective when the narrator conveys a character’s silence, hesitation, fear, greed or helplessness through events; when a solution

is announced in fully formulated statements, the plurality of meaning becomes restricted.

Maithili folk expressions, the vocabulary of everyday village conduct, unforced humour, forms of address and speech ranging from courteous to discourteous constitute the collection's linguistic identity. Language is chiefly a means of bringing the subject close to the reader, rather than an exercise in ornamental Sanskritised prose. Yet, in stories concerning politics and justice, modern terminology associated with public policy appears alongside popular expression. This mixture registers the changing experience of contemporary society.

Separate Textual Analyses of the Twenty Stories

Aadambar

The collection's first story begins with the observance of a shraddha rite. Its opening line—'Today is the shraddha of Sankat's father' (p. 1)—immediately establishes the entire social situation. The story, however, concentrates less on the privacy of grief than on the public scene of the rite: the number of guests, the feast, labour and the balance of prestige. Sankat's family occasion comes under the collective gaze of the village, and the gap between 'showing everyone' and 'actually doing the work' grows wider.

The real object of the story's satire is not the existence of ritual but its exhibitionist public form. An elaborate occasion does not necessarily establish human sympathy. When rites associated with the memory of parents become a social competition, an inversion of values becomes visible. In the closing section, questions, answers and argument urge the reader to consider alternatives to ostentation. Its position as the title story makes it the interpretive gateway to the volume, although some extended conversations also slow the narrative movement.

Ropal Gaachh Babur

At the beginning, Bhan and his wife Rita are awaiting the sympathy of their village. The episode presents people caught between familial injustice and social conduct. The title Ropal Gaachh Babur draws upon an idiom: one's earlier decisions and conduct are linked to their consequences. Because the story unfolds in a climate of social judgement, however, it is insufficient to regard it merely as the private 'punishment for a mistake'.

The story reflects on the relationship between self-determination, social responsibility and the consequences of personal relationships. When recollections of earlier decisions are placed alongside present helplessness, morality becomes a lived experience rather than an exhortation. The return towards the village and the reconsideration of relationships near the end prevent the narrative from becoming wholly punitive. Another question deserves attention: how does a community take the right to dispense justice into its own hands, and what space remains within that process for the voices of those who suffer?

Pashchatap

Illness, poverty and the instability of family life are at the centre of Pashchatap ('Remorse'). Raghav's sickness, the difficulty of obtaining treatment, limited means and the compulsion to seek assistance from relatives immediately ground the narrative in social reality. Poverty is not an abstract misfortune here, but a concrete condition that restricts access to medical care.

Towards the end, the examination of social relationships and earlier conduct assumes importance. Remorse does not remain merely a private state of mind; it becomes associated with questions of assistance, responsibility and social neglect. The storyteller's sympathy is with the suffering family, but a critical question remains: to what extent can personal remorse resolve structural problems of treatment, livelihood and social security? The literary effect is greatest where the characters' insecurity emerges through concrete events rather than through dialogue alone.

Ojha Lekhen Gaam Bataah

This story offers a pointed example of public judgement in the village and political ridicule. The popular formulation involving an 'ojha' and a 'mad village' in its title becomes a satire on the incoherence of collective decisions. Village discussions raise questions about representation, voting, political leaders and practical usefulness. The characters inquire into the public order; the satire falls not only upon individual folly but also upon collective political helplessness.

The story's conversational method resembles a folk stage, where one question produces another. This technique allows the reader to experience village debate. Its limitation is that the balance between political exposition and narrative events becomes uneven in places. Nevertheless, the story rejects the simplified notion that villages exist 'outside politics': rural people understand politics, endure its practical consequences and criticise it as well.

Aarakshan

In Aarakshan ('Reservation'), questions of social disadvantage, justice, opportunity and representation emerge through the structure of village conversation. Rather than presenting reservation merely as the announcement of a government rule, the story portrays a conflict between competing understandings of equality. The characters' questions suggest that one conception of 'justice' involves redressing historical deprivation, while another centres on anxieties about present competition and merit. Through this conflict, the narrative becomes a record of contemporary social attitudes.

Given the social and political subject, criticism must not automatically treat a character's statement as the author's verified conclusion. Arguments must be distinguished from the experiences of particular characters. The closing emphasis on representation and the public good points towards democratic discussion. Actual deprivation, however, requires a broader historical context than individual examples can provide; the story's discursive significance lies more in its questions and answers than in the solution offered.

Loktantra

Loktantra ('Democracy') opens with a character's expression of everyday frustration (p. 37). The meaning of democracy is questioned amid an ordinary person's hardships, the uncertainty of earning a livelihood and the distance separating elected representatives from citizens. Democracy is measured here not simply by the act of voting but by the availability of justice, dignity and effective rights in the citizen's life.

In this story, the language of political debate merges with everyday village speech. Dialogue between characters operates as a popular-language response to administrative discourse. The final section brings out the relationship between economic dependence and political representation. The narrative intensifies the opposition between the ideal of equality and the reality of life in deprivation. Its discursive range is a strength, but lengthy passages of argument also risk weakening narrative tension.

Rail-Yatra

Rail-Yatra brings together reservation, travel, fellow passengers and the conduct of public services. Ordinary matters such as seats, entitlements and amenities become questions of social status and administrative behaviour in the experience of rural travellers. The railway carriage is a small public society in which people from different circumstances, classes and outlooks encounter one another for a brief time.

The story's chief distinguishing feature is the mobility of its setting. In place of the settled conversations of the village, the accidents of a journey offer occasions for argument. But discussion repeatedly turns towards questions of policy, so the artistic possibilities of railway scenes, sounds and physical discomfort remain insufficiently developed. The storyteller seeks to show the gap between public regulations and actual conduct, using the journey as a means of social examination.

Etek Jaati Kiek?

One of the collection's longer stories develops an argument concerning the basis of caste, social division, respect and humanity. The interrogative title —'Why So Many Castes?'—itself addresses the reader. The work does not merely count castes; it attempts to understand how the division between 'us' and 'them' is reinforced in social dealings. Questions of dignity and social distance become clear in the context of everyday life.

Different characters put forward arguments reflecting social beliefs about caste. This makes the text a linguistic record of debates of its time, but it would be risky to regard every idea presented as an established historical fact. From the perspective of scientific social inquiry, caste is not merely a straightforward outcome of the division of labour; it is also an institution of power, birth-based hierarchy and exclusion. As the story turns towards unity and mutual respect, its ethical aspiration becomes clear; its particular narrative qualities should be considered against this background of ideas.

Laash

The title Laash ('Corpse') immediately suggests death, but the story becomes an examination of how the living behave. At the outset, it introduces Kumar Saheb, whose background is that of the landed gentry, and refers to family, property and social relationships. The story gradually overturns the expectation that death naturally brings out the ethics of kinship. The contradiction between family responsibility and the attraction of property becomes increasingly pronounced.

In the final section, the presence of the dead body and the weakening of living relationships become an exceptionally sharp point of satire. Where respect for the body is essential, the interests of inheritance and the relationships that existed during the person's lifetime assert themselves all the more strongly. The significance of Laash lies in this unsettling image: the deceased is not simply an object but becomes the silent centre of a test of family values. The ethical proposition is relatively explicit, yet the visual irony remains its more enduring artistic achievement.

Heart Attack

This story recounts episodes connected with the life, position, income and familial aspirations of a school-associated character named Manohar Babu. The English medical term in the title introduces the insecurities of the modern urban middle class into a more traditional world of social fiction. The relationship between health, wealth and aspiration occupies the centre of the narrative events.

Towards the end, the effect of a sudden heart attack calls the plans of a lifetime into question. The realisation that the extent of one's acquisitions and savings cannot guarantee control over life gives the story a direction of moral satire. At the artistic level, the sudden outcome is effective. But if the event is read merely as a moral 'punishment', the complex human experience of illness and death risks being oversimplified. It is necessary to distinguish between these two possibilities while reading the story.

Begaar

At its very opening, Begaar ('Forced Labour') underlines the difference between official arrangements and actual conditions: 'Nowadays, according to government regulations, no one may keep a person in begaar, that is, as a bonded labourer' (p. 85). The ensuing events portray the life relationships between a powerful village family and dependent labourers. The story's tension emerges from the distance between announcing the operation of a formal rule and actually ending social dependence.

This is a particularly significant story because exploitation is presented not simply as the disposition of a cruel employer but as a system sustained by poverty, debt, livelihood and social standing. Episodes involving Kamla and Vishwanath Babu's family raise questions about the labourer's dignity and the right to make decisions. By the end, the social meaning of 'begaar' is shown to extend beyond its legal prohibition. The story envisages the ethical possibility

of change in individual conduct, but leaves unanswered the need to transform wider economic relationships in order to end structural exploitation.

Pari-Katha

Pari-Katha ('Fairy Tale') offers an experiment in storytelling distinct from the collection's realistic social sphere. Beginning with the introduction of a king, a prince and a conventional narrative situation, it brings the reader onto familiar folk-tale ground. Human desire, judgement and relationships are tested within episodes concerning royal power and the royal family.

The presence of the word 'fairy' in the title does not automatically justify classifying the story as children's literature; to do so would be an error of literary genre. A fairy tale may be received by children, but its actual generic position depends upon the composition of its readership, linguistic level, fear and wonder, presentation of morality and narrative extent. The allegory involving the prince and the ethical argument within this story are also relevant to mature readers. Its distinctive feature is the extraction of new social meanings from the structure of a folk tale; its more explicit discussion at the end diminishes the atmosphere of mystery.

Kukuruk Naangari

The title's unusual image, grounded in folk speech, arouses the reader's curiosity. The story is built from episodes concerning a prosperous householder, rural dependency, social humiliation and human conduct. The use of animal imagery belongs to a tradition of attacking human behaviour through allegory; the narrative context must determine to whom the image of the 'dog' is applied here and in what circumstances.

The story asks how a person comes to be belittled within unequal relationships of power, and to what extent that person can preserve self-respect. Examining the social causes of the characters' actions is more useful than merely assigning them to moral categories. The demand for human dignity is explicit at the end; the writer turns the language of ridicule back against society. Nevertheless, the ethical effect of an animal comparison itself deserves questioning, since criticism of humiliation can sometimes reproduce images of humiliation in its own language.

Lati

Lati begins with a scene of uncontrolled laughter, incongruous behaviour and a condition resembling intoxication on a village road. A character's body and speech become a spectacle before the social gaze. Yet to regard Lati solely as an individual vice would unduly restrict the story; questions of family, economic duty and social embarrassment are connected with the condition.

As the narrative develops, the perspectives of the individual and the family confront one another. The desire to change a person's conduct follows a familiar pattern of moral reform, but the psychological and social complexity of addiction or repeatedly compulsive behaviour does not emerge in full. Critics must not regard the satirised character merely as an object of laughter.

The story provides evidence of how uncontrolled habits can become a crisis within the family; the balance between compassion and blame is its central test.

Kavik Jingi

The social position of the creative writer is an important theme in this story. Its opening comparison—'A poet's life is exactly like a lamp that illuminates others, while darkness surrounds it on every side' (p. 124)—forms the centre of its pathos and satire. The image of light establishes a contrast between the public benefit of creative work and the poet's personal deprivation.

The narrative raises questions about the unstable recognition given to creative labour, the poet's sense of self and public neglect. The tension between the symbolic ideal of poetic talent and material respect in everyday life belongs to the social history of literary institutions. The story may also be called a self-reflexive literary parable. Its significance in this form lies not merely in glorifying the poet, but in questioning the discrepancy between literature's social usefulness and the writer's actual life. The episode concerning institutional recognition at the end makes personal suffering a public issue.

Udyan

Udyan ('Garden') is concerned with tensions between private family relationships and public roles. Episodes involving father and daughter, marriage, financial circumstances and changing human equations give the story a domestic emotional setting. Its title naturally suggests beauty, growth and possibility; the questions of social conduct within the narrative turn this agreeable suggestion into irony.

The story is short, so its movement from event to consequence is relatively rapid. Questions of power and expectation in private relationships are complex: who has the authority to define a family's 'welfare'? In places the story relies upon an individual's moral improvement as a solution. If the title's symbolism had been developed more fully through scenes, its emotional effect might have been denser; nevertheless, brevity also protects the story from unnecessary digressions.

Narak Ke Yatra

This story uses religious beliefs in karma, heaven and hell to examine social conduct. Its opening sentence—'People say that after death a being goes to heaven or hell' (p. 138)—takes popular belief as its starting point; it does not offer a scientifically verified account of the afterlife. The allegorical journey opens possibilities for satire about a person's deeds, self-examination and the social use of religious language.

The landscape of hell is not literal geography but a moral imagining. Scriptural images and unethical actions in everyday life illuminate one another. The movement towards religious recollection and prayer at the close

gives the story a familiar didactic ending. From a literary point of view, the important distinction is between generating fear and awakening self-criticism: they are two different acts. Through this tension, the story reveals the structure of belief within popular religion.

Sanket

Sanket ('Indication') begins with episodes involving a familiar family, a poet and personal relationships. Ordinary domestic conversation and the indirect language of suggestion combine to give the story intimacy. Here, instead of explicit argument, the narrator relies more heavily on the gradual disclosure of a situation and the reader's inference about relationships.

Towards the end, reflections emerge on life's uncertainty, human affection and social conduct. The story's meaning is linked with its title: not everything important is stated in declarative sentences; conduct, too, communicates through signs. Read alongside the collection's political satires, the work reveals a different artistic possibility: comparatively less direct discourse and greater emotional tension. Nevertheless, the narrator's moral interpretation becomes explicit once again at the conclusion.

Arajal Bhog

Arajal Bhog offers a satirical examination of rural social standing, family celebrations, property and relationships. It opens with the family of Chanda and aspirations concerning marriage. The bustle of arrangements creates an image of outward joy, but the differing intentions of people and the unequal distribution of resources produce varied meanings beneath the celebration.

The story's critical significance lies in its recognition that feasts and festivities are not merely scenes of eating but also displays of social hierarchy. Imagined family prosperity, kinship expectations and the pressure of spending converge. Towards the end, the circumstances of the marriage decision and the scale of decoration leave questions of social evaluation open. The story establishes an intertextual connection with the theme of public display in the title story Aadambar, but the debate shifts here from communal religious rites to a private family celebration.

Jaani Ka Besahab

The final story begins by referring to a popular television quiz show: 'One day I was watching TV. The programme was Kaun Banega Crorepati' (p. 156). The prospect of acquiring wealth becomes the gateway to a moral thought experiment. Gradually, the story reaches questions of earning, enjoyment, charity, hospitality, poverty and religious merit.

Within this structure, traditional moral parable confronts modern consumerist aspiration. At the end, a dialogue between Sethji and Mahatmaji raises questions about virtuous deeds and genuine assistance. The value of a moral decision lies less in the display of wealth than in the conduct of life. The story may be read as a conclusion to a collection opposed to ostentation: how far do people actually practise the values for which they seek admiration?

Although the narrative articulates its lesson very directly, the continuity of its ideas from title to ending gives the collection a coherent close.

Integrated Evaluation of Narrative Craft

The Arrangement of Titles, Irony and Ideational Unity

A survey of the twenty titles reveals a distinctive duality. Titles such as Aadambar, Begaar, Laash, Aarakshan, Loktantra and Sanket point towards the complexity of social institutions and abstract ideas, while Ropal Gaachh Babur, Ojha Lekhen Gaam Bataah, Kukuruk Naangari and Jaani Ka Besahab arise from popular sayings and the memory of vernacular speech. Pari-Katha and Narak Ke Yatra suggest the possibilities of parable, while Heart Attack and Rail-Yatra carry the accents of contemporary experience. This variety demonstrates the breadth of the storyteller's subject matter.

The collection's unity of ideas lies in a recurring question: what form do the things publicly called merit, justice, prestige, progress or morality actually take in lived experience? Through this question the separate stories illuminate one another. Aadambar and Arajal Bhog portray ceremonial display; Aarakshan and Etek Jaati Kiek? address justice and social division; Laash and Heart Attack deal with life, death and property; while Begaar and Loktantra juxtapose rights with the realities of existence.

Dialogue, Narrator and the Construction of Scenes

Debate is the storyteller's favoured structure. Characters ask questions, several answers follow, and the narrative proceeds towards an ethical conclusion. This resembles the oral tradition of storytelling: disputation at court, conversation at the village chaupal, domestic quarrels and the companionship of a journey all have ordinary speech as their narrative thread. The technique keeps the language alive and renders questions of ideas accessible to ordinary readers.

In many stories, however, the distinctive development of speaking characters is subordinated to the pressure of theoretical discussion. The extensive exposition of ideas in Etek Jaati Kiek?, political debate in Aarakshan and Loktantra, and discussion of religious ethics in Jaani Ka Besahab are central narrative attractions, but the writer's overt partisanship sometimes leaves readers less room for independent interpretation. By contrast, the dead body in Laash, the economic dependence in Begaar and the metaphor of light and darkness in Kavik Jingi are scenic or symbolic centres that create a readerly experience rather than merely state conclusions.

Language: The Speech of the Maithili Village and Public Thought

Maithili narration preserves forms of address rooted in folk life, interrogative constructions, idioms, rhythms of argument and the subtle gradations of social distance. The impression of authentic speech arises not merely from an abundance of unusual words but from the situations of life, characters' social positions and the tones of dialogue. In Aadambar, the arrangements and contempt associated with feasting; in Loktantra,

resentment concerning popular sovereignty; and in Begaar, the contradiction between law and conduct—all reveal language as a bearer of social knowledge.

Where administration, justice or education are discussed, the coexistence of political and social terminology with the folk rhythms of Maithili reveals the linguistic circumstances of the period. The collection therefore has documentary significance from a linguistic perspective. Nevertheless, more fully developed distinctions in speech suited to individual characters and more scene-specific renderings of sound would have increased the narrative's multiplicity of levels.

Female Characters, Family and Critical Limitations

The presence of women such as Rita, Kamla and Seema offers opportunities to examine women's emotional positions within social decision-making. Yet in many stories the principal bearers of political or publicly ethical arguments are male characters. Although questions of social injustice are raised, women's financial authority, desires, experiences of marriage and autonomous narrative perspectives are not developed with equal depth throughout. Discussing this imbalance does not mean rejecting the work; rather, it amounts to a critical examination of its social realism.

A second limitation is the repeated appearance of instructional conclusions in the final sentences of stories. Ethical commitment has its own literary tradition, but an important quality of the modern short story is also its capacity to leave questions open, create emotional uncertainty and make the reader a co-author of interpretation. Aadambar oscillates between these two tendencies. Its affinity is with publicly educative storytelling, but its finest scenes carry it beyond the limits of moral instruction.

Comparative Discussion with the History of Maithili Children's Literature

The Necessary Distinction between Social Fiction and Children's Stories

A fundamental precaution is necessary in assessing Aadambar: the author's other work Swarna-Kamal is listed in Videha's book catalogue as a children's novel, while the publication details and contents of Aadambar clearly identify it as a short-story collection. It is therefore not possible to classify all of the author's writings as 'children's literature'. A title such as Pari-Katha, or a moral narrative form, may be accessible to children; nevertheless, readership age, the reader's prior knowledge, narrative structure, violent or complex social situations and linguistic difficulty together determine generic classification.

The primary criterion for children's literature is not simply 'teaching'. A children's story gives space to the child's centre of experience, play, curiosity, imagination, immediate scenes, independent questions and emotional responsiveness. An adult social story does not necessarily become a children's story by imparting a moral lesson. Many conversations in Aadambar about reservation policy, caste, bonded labour, political representation, conflicts over property and religious ethics are more intelligible when grounded in

adult social experience. Its relationship to children's literature is thus one of 'generic comparison', not direct classification.

Folktales, Printed Children's Books and Digital Preservation

The earliest foundations of the history of storytelling for Maithili children can be found in oral folktales, children's songs, stories told by elders at home, animal tales and moral parables. Modern printed children's books have extended this oral heritage through illustrations, school curricula, science, adventure stories, children's drama and translation. It would be mistaken to regard this history as a single linear progression: oral, printed and digital forms continue to coexist today.

Videha's Shishu Utsav and its children's literature catalogues contain numerous entries for translated picture stories, original stories for children, children's poetry, plays, scientific writing and novels. Among the examples are Munni Kamat's Chukka (a collection of children's stories), Sujit Kumar Jha's Koili Ghuri Aau (a collection of very short stories for children), Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi's Vigyank Batkahi, and Preeti Thakur's series of translated picture stories. These lists establish that contemporary Maithili children's literature is not restricted to uniform moralistic storytelling, but encompasses illustration, science, performance, translation and different readership ages. Independent analysis of the contents of these works lies beyond this essay's scope; that distinction itself clarifies the difference between historical comparisons based on lists and direct critical readings of texts.

The Generic Difference between Nand's Social Fiction and Swarna-Kamal

Videha's book catalogue identifies Swarna-Kamal as a children's novel by Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand', whereas Aadambar is listed as a short-story collection. These differing generic identities attached to works published under the same author's name are particularly meaningful. On the one hand, a children's novel is expected to provide a narrative journey, wonder, a child's imaginative life and creative self-sufficiency. On the other, the social stories in Aadambar depend upon questions and answers concerning adult social institutions, judgement and social experience.

A work such as Pari-Katha reveals a borderland between these classifications. A traditional narrative about kings and princes may attract children, while its ethical discussions and social satire also permit rereading at an adult level. Even after recognising this flexibility, it would not be appropriate to pronounce the author's established children's novel and his collection of social stories to be works of the same genre.

Moral Purpose, the Child's Perspective and Civic Education

Many stories in Aadambar take up justice, respect for labour, equality, compassion, judgement and criticism of greed. These subjects undoubtedly have potential uses in civic education and adolescent curricula. For instance, Begaar could provide material for a discussion of workers' rights; Etek Jaati Kiek? for prejudice; Kavik Jingi for creative labour; and Narak Ke Yatra for ethical decisions. Curricular use, however, is not the same as literary genre.

A new, child-centred presentation would require brief scenes, age-appropriate background, sensitive language concerning caste or class oppression, open-ended questions, accessible introductions to characters, and perhaps the form of a picture story or dramatic adaptation. Rather than teaching every ethical claim in the original as an indisputable truth, children might be asked: who suffered injustice, why did it happen, what else might have been done, and how freely did the characters make their choices? Aadambar could then serve as a valuable companion text for social education. Such a possible use does not imply that the original work is itself children's literature.

The Multiple Currents of Children's Literature in Contemporary Videha

The separate entries in Videha's Shishu Utsav for children's songs, picture stories, scientific narration, folktales, translations, drama and adolescent writing reflect a contemporary process of collection and preservation. Listings of Gajendra Thakur's many children's novels, new stories for adolescents and illustrated stories show that the thematic territory of young readers has extended to science, imagination, social life and contemporary technology. These entries provide material for literary history; numbers of catalogue entries alone, however, cannot establish claims of literary quality or historical 'firsts'.

Against this background, Aadambar's historical position is more clearly situated in the tradition of adult social satire. Its links with the history of children's literature lie principally in shared orality, moral questions, vernacular language and narrative modes. The expansive imaginative play and autonomous perspective of the child expected in children's literature, by contrast, are not central to this collection. Recognition of this distinction makes it possible to honour the diversity of the writer's creative work appropriately.

A Document of Social History and Literary Autonomy

To describe Aadambar merely as a small tract for moral reform would diminish its literary dimensions; to equate it with fully developed, multilayered modernist narrative technique would also be an exaggeration. The collection stands at the intersection of social realism, satire, parable and argumentative prose. It has documentary importance because it brings ordinary social figures to the centre of fiction. Readers encounter the hypocrisy of rural society, dependence within families, everyday experiences of democracy and questions of literary livelihood.

With this documentary force comes a critical responsibility: the beliefs held by characters must be distinguished from social facts. The history of caste, the effects of reservation, the legal condition of labour and medical causes cannot be verified merely by quoting a literary text. Fiction offers evidence of ideas, experiences and conflicts of value; it is not in itself a sociological survey or a legal report. Recognition of these limits renders the relationship between literary analysis and social research more reliable.

The aspiration towards 'justice' within folk society is the author's ethical centre. Yet justice takes different forms: at times individual reform, at others communal responsibility, political rights or philanthropy. Rather than reducing these differences to a single word, they must be examined in relation to the particular circumstances of each story. The absence of compassion in Laash and economic subordination in Begaar can be described in similar ethical language, but their social causes are not identical. Critical recognition of this difference helps readers understand the variety within the collection.

Conclusion

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Aadambar is a collection of Maithili social fiction centred upon the contradiction between public claims to virtuous conduct and actual behaviour. The narrative journey begins with the ostentation of shraddha rituals and moves through inequalities within families, caste, democracy, railway services, forced labour, the poet's life, religious belief and the ethics of wealth. The recurring thread throughout the twenty stories is the capacity to raise serious social questions from ordinary scenes of folk life. In this sense, the title becomes not merely that of the first story but the moral grammar of the entire collection.

The work's greatest achievements are its natural dialogue in the vernacular, the social experience of ordinary characters and its recognition of irony. The silent image of death in Laash, the distance between law and life in Begaar, the image of the lamp in Kavik Jingi and the final debate on wealth and merit in Jaani Ka Besahab testify to the collection's different creative directions. Its limitations include didacticism, overly explicit final ethical judgements, the length of sociopolitical arguments and the relatively restricted autonomous voices of women. Acknowledging these weaknesses does not diminish the author's social commitment; rather, it establishes the work's artistic position more accurately.

Comparison with the history of children's literature confirms that moral subject matter alone does not constitute children's literature. Aadambar is essentially a collection of social stories for mature readers; selected episodes may be reread profitably in adolescent civic education, while the author's catalogued children's novel Swarna-Kamal requires a separate generic study. With this distinction clearly maintained, Aadambar can be read as a significant work in the traditions of Maithili folk life, social satire and dialogue-centred storytelling.

Part Two

Society, Women's Identity and the Novel

Gudari Ke Lal · Anathiya Kukur · Sujata · Sukanya · Parivar

Chapter 3

Gudari Ke Lal

Feudal Domination, Women's Identity, Education and the Struggle for Justice

Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’’s Gudari Ke Lal is a Maithili novel situated at the intersection of social realism and the aspiration for reform. Set in a rural society before Independence, it raises questions concerning the exploitation of landless labourers, the dominance of landlords, the class allegiance of the police and administration, control over women's bodies and reputations, the social purpose of education, the self-identification of a new generation, and judicial intervention. Matru and his daughter Sugiya occupy the moral centre of this struggle; Thakur Jalim Singh and his influence over the structures of power put social resistance to the test. In the latter part, the question of Sureshwar's identity and the court proceedings transform private suffering into a question of public justice and social responsibility. This study includes a sequential reading of all twenty-two sections, the characters' internal conflicts, the novel's time and setting, linguistic techniques, women's lives, class structure, the politics of rural education, and comparisons with the tradition of the Maithili social novel. Alongside the work's achievements, it examines the simplification involved in its reformist happy ending, its idealisation of characters, and possible limitations associated with institutional justice.

Maithili novel; Gudari Ke Lal; Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’; Sugiya; Matru; landlordism; education; women's identity; rural society; social justice.

Introduction: The Irony of the Title and the Social Question

Gudari Ke Lal makes creative use of an idiom familiar in the Hindi–Maithili linguistic world: a poor outer covering cannot conceal the human talent and dignity within. The title initially signals an inequality: a person's worth is assessed by wealth, lineage, ownership of land and outward standing, but the story challenges precisely these criteria. By the novel's conclusion, the meaning of the title has become charged with the struggle for social recognition and moral acceptance.

This is a social novel, not a children's novel. Its original publication describes it as a ‘Maithili novel’; it addresses adult social questions such as indications of sexual exploitation, unwilling relationships, humiliation based on class, political and feudal oppression, and judicial decisions. To assess it by the criteria of children's literature would create a confusion of genres. Nevertheless, because of its concern with education and the characters of the younger generation, it may also be useful to research into children's rights and the sociology of education.

In his introduction the author makes clear the historical setting of exploitation, Matru's struggle, the circumstances of Sugiya's life and his faith in social change. The author's declared intention, however, cannot be accepted as the final meaning of the novel. Literary criticism asks how far the episodes impart artistic credibility to this intention and where the novelist's explicit social hopes run ahead of the natural development of the characters.

The Work's Historical Setting and Narrative Design

Gudari Ke Lal was written by Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’. Its publication page names Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Upardaha, Darbhanga, and gives a contribution amount of ₹150. The author's statement concludes with the date Vijayadashami, 2008. We can therefore establish 2008 as the date of that statement; no separate year of publication is clearly specified in the preliminary pages available. The final numbered page of the story is 140. Page references here follow the numbering of the original printed edition.

The author clearly establishes the period in which the story begins:

‘The time was before Independence.’ (Original text, p. 1)

This sentence determines the novel's historical atmosphere, but the author's own statement about the setting and characters is also important. He writes that the characters, time and place belong to an imaginative construction. Ramgarh and the governmental events must therefore not be read as archival history; this is a narrative of an imagined society inspired by historical structures. Its social truth must be tested within the terms of its fictional construction.

The original work unfolds in twenty-two numbered sections. At the outset, landlessness and inequalities of power are established; the middle develops Sugiya's struggle for her existence and for the right to determine the terms of her life; and the latter part moves through education, intergenerational advancement, public differences of opinion and a judicial conclusion.

The Work's Place in the Tradition of the Maithili Social Novel

Social conventions, marriage, the position of women and the realities of local life have remained important concerns throughout the development of the modern Maithili novel. Harimohan Jha's Kanyadan (1933) satirically attacks the marriage practices of society; Dwiragaman (1943) raises questions about women's lives and education in the same milieu. Yatri's Paro (1946) offers a more incisive picture of women's experience and patriarchal structures. Gudari Ke Lal's relationship with these works is not one of inherited imitation but of thematic dialogue.

According to the views of the writer Kathakar Ashok on early Maithili novels, the impulse towards social reform and the realistic depiction of contemporary life were both important tendencies. Gudari Ke Lal brings them together. Class inequality and feudal oppression give it a grounding in reality, yet its conclusion moves towards the hope that society can be reformed. This tension generates both its principal artistic strength and its limitation.

Comparison with the Hindi novel Godan (1936) brings into view similar questions of agrarian exploitation, debt, honour and the helplessness of peasants and labourers. Godan, however, represents the continuing impoverishment of working people in harsher terms, whereas Gudari Ke Lal places greater faith in moral awakening and legal intervention. This is a

comparison of narrative tendencies, not an assertion of direct influence or a source relationship.

Dialogue with Phanishwarnath Renu's Maila Anchal (1954) is also possible at the level of rural power relations, local speech and the political atmosphere of Independence. Nevertheless, Renu's polycentric regional narrative has a different structure from the moral struggle centred on Matru and Sugiya in Gudari Ke Lal.

Overall Plot Design: From the Village to the Courtroom

The novel begins in the village setting of Ramgarh. Land is held by a few families, while landless workers labour for their living. The village school, the landlord's mansion, the local court, the police administration, the market and the town beyond acquire different forms of institutional power within the narrative. Matru's labour and Sugiya's life bear the consequences of social hierarchy.

The administration and feudal influence tend to sustain one another. Through Thakur Jalim Singh's conduct, individual inequality becomes a public injustice. How much autonomy Sugiya retains over decisions about her own life is the novel's most profound ethical question. At several turns, the plot presents the insecurity of a powerless family, the question of land and the social meaning of honour.

Later, education ceases to be merely a route to individual advancement. Sureshwar's development creates a new relationship between family memory and social prohibitions. In the final part, private wrongdoing, honour, property rights and public decisions become subjects of judicial debate. Gudari Ke Lal thus takes the form of a journey from social injustice towards the possibility of justice; nevertheless, the critical question remains whether the wounds of experience disappear automatically once justice has been obtained.

Separate Close Readings of All Twenty-Two Sections

Section One: Ramgarh's Economic Structure and the Work's Central Conflict

The first section clarifies the period, village setting and relations of production. Land is controlled by a few landlords, while the workers who cultivate the fields do not own them. Discussion of the school is placed immediately beside this social inequality. The proximity does not appear accidental: on one side education offers a possibility of advancement; on the other, knowledge and resources are controlled by the prosperous classes. The opening structure gives collective exploitation a place before individual tragedy.

The significance of the section is heightened by an opening sentence such as ‘The time was before Independence’ (p. 1). The pre-Independence period is a historical marker, but village exploitation is not merely the direct consequence of colonial rule; indigenous feudal relations are an independent source of it. This distinction is fundamental to reading the novel as a whole.

Section Two: Labour, Dependence and Everyday Fear

As the opening events develop, the worker's daily routine, the compulsions of livelihood and the mansion's influence remain in view. Exploitation is manifested not only in low wages, but also in the worker's lack of a right to speak, freedom of movement and capacity to protect his family. It is in this setting that Matru's predicament becomes personal.

Through dialogue drawn from everyday social conduct, the author shows that workers cannot immediately formulate the language of rights. First, they must find a way to preserve their families. The story thus brings the destructive effects of class structure onto an emotional plane.

Section Three: Family Insecurity and Feudal Intrusion

Matru's family circumstances and the external pressures upon Sugiya's life now become the story's central social question. Poverty is not simply deprivation: it is a condition of vulnerability to the will of others. The gaze of wealthy men upon a poor man's daughter, and their conduct as though they possessed rights over her, expose the ethical deformation of social relations.

In reading this section one must distinguish between ‘protection’ and ‘control’. What the landlord's side might call shelter or kindness is experienced by a powerless family as fear, compulsion and a risk to its reputation.

Section Four: The Local Court, the Police Inspector and Legal Inequality

In the fourth section, the roles of the police and the inspector give the conflict an institutional dimension. The office of authority is no longer an impartial place for hearing a poor person's complaint; rank, access and partiality influence the course of justice. Matru's appearance before the inspector reveals the distance between possessing the right to seek justice and actually obtaining it.

Here the novelist's social vision grows more concrete. Removing a wicked individual will not by itself change the system: until institutions of authority become independent of pressure from the powerful, the victim's voice will remain insecure.

Section Five: The Limits of Repression and Preparations for Resistance

Episodes of interaction between feudal power and administration turn Matru's personal crisis into social criticism. Whose words will be heard, whose testimony will be considered credible, and whose standing has already been accepted? These questions define the novel's conception of justice.

Within fear, the desire to resist also develops. Resistance does not always appear as a declaration; sometimes it takes the form of plans to protect relatives, requests for assistance from a suitable person, or attempts to articulate the causes of injustice.

Section Six: Sugiya's Awareness and the Question of Ethical Consent

The sixth section places Sugiya's inner insecurity and her understanding of her circumstances at the centre. She attempts to comprehend the balance of power surrounding her. The alternatives before her are not simply the ordinary choices of love or marriage, but the severe questions of social ostracism, her father's helplessness and her future means of subsistence.

A feminist reading is essential here. A decision that looks like consent from outside may in fact have been compelled by fear and deprivation. To glorify Sugiya's position as 'surrender' would diminish its human complexity.

Section Seven: The Language of Power and Economic Claims

In this section the influence of Thakur Jalim Singh and questions of entitlement arising from his relationship with Sugiya acquire a clearer shape. The impulse to determine another person's life through wealth, land and social standing becomes the focus of opposition. Sugiya is no longer merely someone to whom help may be given; she seeks a position from which to discuss the conditions of her future.

The story concerns more than a mere transfer of property. It opens the question of the ethical source of entitlement: kindness, charity or justice? When a wealthy person grants a gift, power may remain in that person's hands; when the right of the powerless is acknowledged, the very basis of the relationship changes.

Section Eight: Plans for Change and the Long Shadow of Distrust

The prospect of rights being recognised does not immediately reassure Sugiya. Her previous experiences make her cautious towards guardianship, generosity and political proposals. The novelist uses a lengthy succession of exchanges, thereby making clear the social weight of the decision.

At this point the novel also discloses the limits of the idea of a male 'rescuer'. The desire to reform society has value, but if a reforming initiative does not listen to the victim's freedom, justice can become a one-sided act of charity once again.

Section Nine: The Political Meaning of Personal Relationships

Personal meetings, assurances and discussions about rights deepen the political character of the narrative. Sugiya's circumstances cannot be contained within a simple division between villains and good people. The possibility of assistance and the memory of domination may coexist within the same person or family.

For this reason conduct matters more here than the characters' declarations. The test of just behaviour is enduring responsibility, not momentary pity.

Section Ten: A New Struggle over Social Standing

Questions of dignity and public recognition arise in relation to Sugiya's life. In village society, private relationships do not remain merely private: they are

judged by standards of caste and lineage, a woman's 'character', wealth and family honour.

The story's principal criticism in this section is directed at this collective gaze. Society can tolerate the influence of a wrongdoer while continuously demanding that the woman who has suffered prove herself. The experience of such a second punishment is an important aspect of the novel's engagement with women's lives.

Section Eleven: The New Generation and the Possibility of Education

As the story proceeds, the younger generation, educated individuals and ideas of social change become prominent. Ajay, Vijay, Rameshwar and other supportive or conversational figures do more than move the plot forwards: they demonstrate that society is not uniform. Opposition to injustice is possible even within prosperous circles.

The significance of this section lies in the possibility of moving beyond individual compassion towards collective judgement. Yet the novel's faith is generally concentrated upon a few virtuous people; a fuller representation of institutions and an organised labour movement would have given change a stronger social foundation.

Section Twelve: Relationships, Deception and an Alternative Morality

In the middle phase of the struggle, familial and social relationships undergo reassessment. Dialogue reveals the difference between outward status and inward ethical conduct. Those called respectable are not invariably just, while those who are poor are not morally inferior in their decisions.

It is useful to read this section in relation to the title's original meaning. The ragged covering signifies outward deprivation; the 'jewel' is the value within that the dominant social gaze is unable to recognise.

Section Thirteen: From Labour to Social Responsibility

Questions of the village's economic crisis, labour and livelihood acquire new meanings in changing circumstances. Some members of the prosperous class show a desire for reform, but one individual's goodwill cannot replace the structural constraints suffered by hundreds of dependants. Here the novelist generates tension between benevolent reform and change founded upon rights.

Critically considered, workers' own organisation and collective resistance have a limited active presence. Nevertheless, the attempt to attach social dignity to conduct and humanity rather than the privilege of birth is a positive achievement of the novel.

Section Fourteen: Upbringing, Educational Opportunity and Class Mobility

At this stage the questions of raising a child, study and the building of a future come to the centre. Through Sureshwar's life, education becomes a genuine possibility for overcoming social barriers. The acquisition of

knowledge means more than literacy: it is a process of finding one's place within language, self-confidence and public institutions.

But educational success also requires support and resources. Almost incidentally, the novel shows that talent alone is not enough: schools, financial assistance, the work of the family and the availability of opportunities shape its development. Here the idiom Gudari Ke Lal acquires a structural significance.

Section Fifteen: A Child's Future and the Rights of Motherhood

With Sugiya's motherhood, the centre of the story begins to shift. The humiliation she suffered earlier does not simply end there; it returns to her life as anxiety over her son's future, education and social identity.

To read motherhood solely as the glorification of sacrifice would obscure Sugiya's independent womanhood. A deeper reading suggests that her insistence upon her son's future is also a claim to lasting control over her own life: she does not wish the violence of her experience to be repeated upon the next generation.

Section Sixteen: Sureshwar's Educational Journey and Self-Identity

Sureshwar's story gives concrete human form to social mobility. Experience of an educational world beyond the deprivation of the village prepares a generation unwilling to remain bound by the social limits assigned at birth.

The novel's optimism is especially clear through this character. Yet it would be hasty to infer the progress of the entire working class from the success of one educated son. The achievement of exceptional talent does not automatically abolish social inequality; it may instead make that inequality more visible.

Section Seventeen: A Test of Relations with the Elite

In the later phase, questions of identity, social acceptance and family ties grow acute once more. Sureshwar's educated personality brings about a change in the outlook of prosperous families. How much of this change represents acceptance of his humanity, and how much an attraction to success? The question cannot be avoided.

If a poor person is deemed worthy of respect only after becoming educated and successful, the fundamental logic of social discrimination may remain unchanged. Testing the novel's reformist hope against this criterion offers one of its most useful critical readings.

Section Eighteen: Village, Family and Social Memory

Memories of old relationships, land and family obligations acquire new meanings in a changed setting. Past injustice is no longer merely an occurrence; it becomes a basis for present decisions. Sugiya and her child carry this inheritance of honour and dishonour in their lives.

The emotional force of this section lies in the incompleteness of memory. Whether one is displaced or advances in life, the claims of village relationships and the mother's lived experience do not simply disappear.

Section Nineteen: The Public Voice of Ethical Judgement

Personal differences turn into social debate. How legitimate are claims concerning property, relationships and standing? Their validity can no longer be determined solely by the wishes of the head of a family.

The function of this brief transitional section is to prepare the conceptual ground for the final conflict. What was earlier silenced through fear now becomes a possible subject of public discussion.

Section Twenty: Legal Strategy and Feudal Discomfort

In the final political and judicial phase, the prestige of the Thakur faction, memories of landlordism and a new consciousness of rights confront one another. For people accustomed to older practices, the very act of public questioning is a challenge.

Here the conflict shifts from physical force towards speech, documentation, legal argument and moral accountability. This transformation is a structural achievement of the novel.

Section Twenty-One: Pride of Lineage, Justice and Social Reckoning

Questions concerning Jalim Singh, Sugiya, Sureshwar and their relatives gain renewed intensity. The violence concealed within the language of social hierarchy, the legitimacy of children and family prestige becomes visible. The characters arrive at a decisive question of social acceptance.

The section's critical value lies in the fact that justice comes to mean not simply defeating the guilty, but acknowledging the victim with her own name and relationships. Nevertheless, the limitation of attaching human dignity to marital or genealogical recognition also becomes visible.

Section Twenty-Two: The Court, Renewed Recognition and the Full Meaning of the Title

The final section brings the narrative to its conclusion through a courtroom hearing. Judgement falls upon the social and moral consequences of the events involving Jalim Singh; Sugiya's humiliation and relationships can no longer be suppressed as merely private matters. The Thakur's former position, Sugiya's struggle and Sureshwar's character converge at a single narrative point.

Through Sugiya's acceptance and the renewal of the family, the author presents an optimistic vision of social justice in the final episode. Legal proceedings are developed from printed page 132 onwards, while the reactions of family and society on pages 138–140 take the story towards its conclusion. On the last page, regret is expressed that genuine human worth was not recognised earlier. It is through this recognition that the ethical meaning of the title emerges.

One serious question nevertheless remains: in what way do the court's decision and the family's acceptance address Sugiya's former suffering? When narrative justice centres upon personal reconciliation, the question of wider transformation against structural exploitation remains unfinished. This limitation must be considered alongside the novel's humanistic achievement.

Matru: The Life of a Labourer, Fatherhood and Resistance

Matru is the first concrete foundation of the novel's social reality. His labour sustains society's productive arrangements, yet land and rights are not in his hands. Such an economic position also constrains his familial decisions. He longs to protect his daughter, but his capacity to do so is endangered in the face of feudal power.

Matru's moral dignity does not lie in his becoming an all-powerful hero. On the contrary, despite his weakness he tries to preserve the meaning of relationships, labour and self-respect. This is important in literary terms: the representation of injustice becomes effective only when the victim is not merely a figure of suffering, but a human being possessing his own judgement.

At times, however, the author makes Matru's struggle dependent upon individual assistance. The lengthy social process of organised labour resistance is not developed with comparable force. The work is consequently less an epic of the labour movement than a novel of a deprived family's moral struggle.

Sugiya: Bodily Autonomy, Dignity and the Limits of Choice

Sugiya is the most complex and ethically significant character in Gudari Ke Lal. The author's preliminary statement places her life at the centre of social exploitation. According to that statement, Sugiya suffers an outcome regarded as dishonourable by society and, having no favourable alternatives, makes a decision about her relationship. The statement should not be treated as indisputable evidence of consent. Without asking how freely consent could have been given within unequal power relations, no profound reading of Sugiya is possible.

The novel exposes a society disposed to remain silent about male violence while imposing a permanent stigma upon a woman's life. Sugiya experiences suffering twice over: first through the unequal relationship, and then through the judgement of others. Education and the support of the new generation challenge this stigma.

Yet it is not enough to establish Sugiya's dignity merely through motherhood, marriage or final familial acceptance. She is an independent person, with a consciousness of herself that extends beyond motherhood. Such a feminist interpretation deepens the work's human possibilities, even though the novelist does not develop them fully.

Thakur Jalim Singh: Lineage, Power and the Legitimisation of Wrongdoing

Thakur Jalim Singh is not merely an opposing individual; he represents feudal relations. His standing rests upon land, lineage, influence and fear. The

novel shows that social inequality reveals its real power when the wealthy class enforces its desires as though they were rules.

Jalim Singh's character contains the potential for a conflict between power and conscience. The story ultimately opens a route towards change and acceptance, but the credibility of that change depends upon a gradual process of moral self-criticism. For the reader, a final act of generosity alone cannot erase responsibility for previous injustice.

Feudal prestige is criticised repeatedly within the narrative, but the question of how its wider institutional structure will change after the legal outcome receives relatively brief treatment.

Sureshwar and the New Generation: The Ambivalence of Social Mobility

Through Sureshwar's life, the title opens towards the future. When talent flourishing within disadvantaged conditions is given an opportunity for education, it acquires the capacity to cross the barriers of the past. Such moral optimism is an important source of the work's energy.

Yet social mobility also has an ambivalent character. On one hand, a figure who demonstrates his abilities through education invalidates society's judgements based upon caste and lineage. On the other, if society honours him only after his success, office or prestigious associations, its underlying prejudice remains. Reading Sugiya and Sureshwar together makes this distinction clear.

The novel's commitment to education is ethically important, but a deeper social analysis of access to educational institutions, costs, language and class resources could have strengthened its realism.

Supporting Characters: Ajay, Vijay, Rameshwar, Sharda and the Judicial World

Beyond the central triangle, several characters make the story more many-sided. Young people such as Ajay and Vijay, Rameshwar, Sharda Babu, the police inspector, figures associated with the school, and court officials disclose different levels of social relations. They represent different shades of dissent within the prosperous class, educated morality, administrative partisanship and the possibility of reform.

On the basis of these figures, one may say that the novel does not consider society uniformly wicked or uniformly good. Reform-minded people may exist even within an exploiting class, and an institution that is supposed to hear demands for justice may itself be unjust. This dynamism in the arrangement of characters increases the work's critical importance.

Some supporting characters, however, become representatives of ideas rather than fully realised people during long exchanges. Greater development of their individual language, memory and uncertainty would have given them fuller human presence.

Narrative Craft: Time, Extended Dialogue and Ethical Purpose

Gudari Ke Lal is a sequential, event-driven narrative. The opening social structure is followed by a family crisis, changing forms of personal relationship, intergenerational change through education and, finally, a judicial outcome. This sequence gives the novel an extended temporal range. The narrative begins before Independence, but its final judicial system points towards a later, historically altered context. Understanding the sequence of events within this transition of time is essential.

In some places the author relies upon extended dialogue instead of direct narration. Conversations between Sugiya and the Thakur faction address gifts, land, rights and her future. The advantage is that the ideological positions of the characters become clear. The drawback is that at times the characters seem less like independently speaking people than spokespeople for the author's reformist ideas.

The courtroom section reverses the violent exercise of power found at the opening: where force and fear previously determined decisions, reason and public legal procedure now become possible. This structural inversion is a noteworthy achievement of the novel's craft.

Language and Rural Reality

The novel's language is primarily the Maithili of everyday interaction. Expressions such as ‘hamra’, ‘tora’, ‘ahan’, ‘kakaro’, ‘bajalah’, ‘saunse’ and ‘gap’ signal social relationships through their use in dialogue. Rural vocabulary and the lexical world of cultivation, hired labour, the mansion, the threshold, the court office and the school produce a sense of social reality.

The language is most effective where a character's manner of speaking reveals that person's social position without explanation. Fear, deference, dissent and self-respect may shift within a single sentence. Extended explanations and repetition sometimes arrest the movement of the story; this is a limitation of craft, not a denial of the value of its vernacular voice.

From an editorial perspective, more restrained dialogue and a reduction of repeated accounts of facts already established through events could have increased the novel's impact. Its distinctly Maithili linguistic character nevertheless remains among its chief achievements.

Feminism and Social Justice: Consent, Marriage and Social Forgiveness

The most difficult question concerns the treatment of Sugiya. Men's power over women's bodies and society's control of their reputations are interrelated. Consequently, even an ostensibly ‘respectable’ option may be compulsory for a woman who has suffered. Judged by the ethics of literature, the ultimate recognition of marriage or family is no self-evident substitute for legal process and a reckoning with earlier violence.

When the novel gives voice to Sugiya's resistance and sorrow, it stands against patriarchal convention. But when the final resolution centres on social

acceptance, the possibility of an entirely autonomous life beyond patriarchy is not developed at comparable length. This ambivalence may be regarded as a limitation of the work's historically situated social reformism.

The novelist's human purpose matters: a woman should not be left permanently imprisoned in disgrace. Yet the modern reader must ask whether dignity is a recognition bestowed by society or an inalienable right possessed from the outset. The novel provides rich ground for this debate.

Landlessness, Landlordism and Institutional Exploitation

The opening village situation establishes land as a source of power. Workers cultivate the fields, but they do not own the land. This division creates economic dependence, which in turn becomes the basis for political fear and social subordination. The reach of the mansion's influence into police conduct is the institutional manifestation of this power relation.

Landownership and the abolition of zamindari were major public questions in twentieth-century Bihar. Records of the Bihar Land Reforms Act, 1950, clarify the legal background to the change. But it would be inappropriate to claim that the fictional events of the novel directly document any particular effects of that law. The law provides comparative historical context, not a record of the plot.

The novel's concluding reformist resolution poses a problem: Matru's family is not the only victim of landlord exploitation; the village has many labourers. In such conditions, restoring the standing of one family, however important, is not equivalent to achieving justice for an entire class. This difference is decisive for a critical assessment of the work.

Education: A Right to Opportunity, Not a Gift of Compassion

The school's presence at the beginning, and the social influence of the educated younger generation towards the end, form a long symbolic thread. In the first phase education is close to the resources of the wealthy; in the later phase, that same education becomes a means of countering inequalities fixed by birth.

The title Gudari Ke Lal is not merely a consequence of this argument but its basis: poverty is not proof of a lack of talent. This idea, however, becomes a complete social principle only when everyone is provided equal means through which ability can be recognised. Education must therefore be conceived as a collective right rather than a favour conferred upon individuals.

Matru's and Sugiya's experiences lend human depth to this modern educational ideal. Social change does not mean simply producing an outstanding student; it also means ensuring the dignity of that student's family and of other people in the same class position.

The Judicial Epilogue: Legal Justice and Social Restoration

The courtroom episode in the final section lends public authority to the narrative's resolution. At first, the powerless person's voice was blocked before

the landlord and the police; at the end, disputes over social status and private relationships become matters of argument before the court. Through this sequence, the novelist expresses optimistic faith in the justice system.

A significant sentence in the final part articulates the central principle of judicial propriety:

'But I am bound by the law.' (Original text, p. 136)

The sentence signifies more than a courtroom formality. It reveals the difference between a judge's personal goodwill and a decision consistent with law. Judicial procedure claims to offer a public standard distinct from personal affection, anger or the dominance of family prestige.

Even so, legal victory and social justice are not synonymous. Social rehabilitation, women's autonomy, workers' land rights and punishment for institutional oppression cannot all be fully resolved by a single judgement. At this point, the work's optimistic ending invites the reader's independent critical judgement.

The Title's Ultimate Meaning and the Work's Ethical Achievement

On its last printed page, the novel ends with regret at society's inability to recognise a 'jewel in rags'. The title thus ceases to be merely an idiom about a talented child born in poverty; it becomes a figure for the belated recognition of human dignity, social prejudice and remorse.

The final implication is that pride of caste, lineage and property obscures a person's true worth. Those who fail to discern the humanity developing within the ordinary lives before them are in fact losing their own ethical vision.

A major achievement of the novel is that it refuses to confine the story of exploitation to compassionate observation. By relating Sugiya's and Sureshwar's lives to the question of eventual recognition, the author seeks to tell society that standards founded upon birth are capable of change.

Dominant Rasas, Emotional Structure and the Reader's Experience

The karuna rasa, or feeling of pathos, is the novel's principal emotional force. Matru's helplessness, Sugiya's humiliation and the family's insecurity evoke compassion. Social manifestations of raudra and vira, anger and courage, accompany this pathos: indignation at injustice and the desire to oppose it.

In the final stage, anticipation of a court judgement, social recognition and reunion point towards an emotion of tranquillity. Whether that tranquillity erases the entire tragedy, however, depends upon the reader's sensibility. It is here that the work's emotional effect becomes most interesting.

Emotional response alone is not sufficient when reading a narrative of injustice. The work also asks readers to understand the character of the system. In this sense, compassion is an ethical beginning, not a final conclusion.

Kanyadan, Paro and Godan: Comparative Readings

Harimohan Jha's Kanyadan reveals familial and social control over women's marriage through satire. The question of women's lives is expressed in more directly pathetic and dramatic terms in Gudari Ke Lal. Both works examine the moral standards governing marriage and society, but their stylistic foundations differ.

Yatri's Paro is regarded as an important stage in the Maithili novel's movement towards giving women's experiences their own voice. The comparison is useful when reading Sugiya: can a woman's independent will be imagined apart from the social institution of marriage? To what extent does the narrative outcome permit her to answer independently? The woman-centred reading of Paro and the reformist resolution of Gudari Ke Lal cannot be treated as equivalent on these questions.

In Premchand's Godan the peasant's struggle is so deeply bound to economic structures that individual goodwill cannot resolve it. Gudari Ke Lal begins with a comparable portrayal of the exploitation of agricultural workers, but places greater trust in human goodwill, education and successful legal intervention. This difference clarifies the aesthetic direction of the two works.

Such comparative study does not establish that one work was inspired by, or directly followed, another. The similarity concerns social questions, not relations between sources.

Critical Limitations: Reformist Resolve and Artistic Credibility

The work's greatest limitation is the exceptional explicitness of its moral purpose. In many scenes the author's social proposals emerge directly through dialogue. This clarity helps the reader grasp the argument, but reduces the space for artistic ambiguity and independent interpretation.

A second limitation is the imbalance between structural exploitation and individual outcomes. The problems of other village labourers are present at the beginning, but the conclusion focuses largely on justice for Sugiya and her associated family. The private victory matters, yet collective emancipation remains a much broader question.

A third limitation concerns the final definition of women's experience. Sugiya's pain and struggle are moving, but justice is tied very closely to the restoration of the family. Had the possibilities of independent life, social protection and dignity without marriage remained more open, the feminist dimension would have been broader.

A fourth limitation concerns the psychological pace of the characters' final transformation. The passage from intense class pride to moral acceptance calls for sustained inner conflict. In some places the novelist's optimism makes the transition too rapid.

Discussing these limits does not diminish the work's humanistic purpose. Rather, it clarifies the levels on which the novel succeeds and those on which later Maithili social fiction might discover more complex creative possibilities.

Conclusion: Removing the Veil of Inequality and Recognising Human Worth

Gudari Ke Lal deserves a place within the tradition of the Maithili social novel that questions inequalities hidden within local patterns of social conduct. Its story of a pre-Independence village begins with Matru's labour and passes through Sugiya's suffering and struggle for rights, Sureshwar's education and finally public debate in a court of law. Its creative strength lies in combining emotionally driven narrative with an explicit social concern.

Sugiya's struggle shows how economic dependence restricts women's freedom; Sureshwar's story demonstrates the importance of education as a means of resisting social prohibitions; and Jalim Singh's portrayal reveals that the prestige of lineage is no guarantee of moral worth.

The work's final insight is particularly meaningful. Society overlooks those it regards as mere rags, and recognises the real value within them only late in the day. The novel's value, however, lies not simply in the discovery of one talented individual: it criticises the exploitative circumstances that deny recognition to the talent, self-respect and sense of justice of many people.

It is consequently most reasonable to read Gudari Ke Lal as an optimistic, reformist social novel. Some of its resolutions are admittedly simplified when judged by the rigorous demands of realism, but its contribution to the expression of human dignity and social questions in the mother tongue, and to the reconstruction of standing through education, is of literary significance.

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Chapter 4

Anathiya Kukur

Village–City Relations, Class Morality and Social Reconstruction

Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’'s Anathiya Kukur transforms changing relations between the villages and towns of Mithila, economic inequality, ethical responsibility, relations between women and men, judicial procedure and aspirations for rural regeneration into interconnected narrative material. The experiences of Prem and Malti as they move between Delhi and the countryside provide the novel's central thread; the episode involving Vidur raises problems of trust, opportunism and institutional justice within this idealistic structure. Across eleven parts, readers encounter a shifting narrative centre: sometimes the social organisation of rural life, sometimes family intimacy, at other times litigation and financial dealings, and elsewhere the love and marriage of younger characters. The present study examines this multiplicity both as the novel's strength and as its limitation. Videha's book catalogue classifies Anathiya Kukur as a ‘novel’ and Swarna Kamal as a ‘children's novel’. Comparison with the history of children's literature is therefore relevant, but it would be inappropriate to classify Anathiya Kukur itself as a children's novel.

Genre and Creative Foundations

The outer cover, the preliminary ‘A Few Words’, the printed sequence of the story and its final page indicate a coherent extended narrative. The available printed copy has a continuous narrative pagination from page 1 to page 245 and is divided into eleven numbered parts. The opening statement bears the author's name, Nand Kumar Mishra, and the date 14 January 2011. That date is taken as the date of the author's statement, not as a definitively established year of publication; the copy does not independently and clearly confirm a publication year. The printed publishing particulars mention ‘Gosainji Baidyanath Smriti Manch’ and Darbhanga.

The primary basis of this essay is the sequence of the original printed text, its divisions, important episodes, relationships among characters and the author's introductory statement. The study seeks to keep the retelling of depicted events separate from critical interpretation.

The work is, in generic terms, a social novel. In ‘A Few Words’, the author particularly raises the distance between rural and urban mentalities, the economic attractions of the city, the village's backwardness, tensions of casteism and communalism, and the need for social reform. Readers may accordingly approach the fictional world as a moral and social proposition by the writer. Criticism, however, must examine the distinction between the introduction and the actual narrative design: how adequately does the story give artistic form to the change the author desires? This is the fundamental question.

Outline of the Plot: From City to Village and from Village Back towards Society

The story opens with a night journey, departure from Delhi towards Rajnagar, the companionship of Prem and Malti, and the arrangements of domestic life (printed p. 1 onwards). Trains, stations, waiting, acquaintances and informal household conversations establish the novel's geographical direction. The emotional centre is not merely the husband and wife, but the wider village society revealed through them. Thereafter the author repeatedly draws comparisons between urban amenities and the difficult conditions of village life.

In the social world of Dhankahi, situations involving education, caste status, labour, farmers, local priests, prosperous families and the disadvantaged come into view. Prem's outlook rests upon the use of rural resources, practical assistance and community dignity. Friendship with Vidur initially inspires hope and trust, but in time financial transactions and disputes involving land call that trust into question. The novelist accumulates many conflicting situations to create sympathy for Prem.

Subsequently, legal proceedings, allegations, affidavits, evidence and office practices sharpen the conflict. The novel thus progresses beyond private morality to questions of institutional ethics. Elsewhere, farmers' fields, the insecurity of rural workers, bullying, theft and mutual accusations impart the immediacy of ordinary life. In later parts, educated young city-dwellers, discussions of love and marriage, religious experiences in Banaras and a return to the central family widen the plot's circumference. Finally, affection connected with the everyday problems of home and village, together with hope for rural reform, becomes prominent (pp. 244–245).

Separate Close Readings of the Eleven Printed Parts

Part One: From a Journey to a Social Map

The first part opens with an account of travel. Prem and Malti's companionship, the bustle of the station, family conversation, the practical needs of domestic life and the easy rhythm of relationships prepare the initial narrative ground. The novelist first creates a tangible atmosphere of experience; local social problems then gradually enter the story. This

arrangement produces a contrast between the mobile time of the city and the apparently stationary experiences of the village.

The presence of Manikant and Sulekha, together with Prem's desire to help society, shows the expansion of personal affection in this part. The protagonist has a pronounced inclination towards altruism. A risk, however, accompanies it: sometimes the narrative leaves aside the complexity of character and begins proclaiming the character's moral qualities. At this stage the idealistic technique still attracts the reader, but continual repetition later may diminish artistic tension.

Towards the end, dialogue brings the need for village service, education and values into view. The opening concerns a private journey, but the ending introduces collective questions; this is the part's important narrative achievement.

Part Two: Dhankahi, Education and Social Inequality

The introduction to Dhankahi depicts the scarcity of resources among poor cultivators and labourers, difficulties of travel, school facilities and the social standing of the teacher Shreemat Chaudhary. Mention of his wife Sunita connects the domestic world with education and public life. This part does not reduce rural deprivation to an emotional tableau; it also indicates its economic foundations.

The relationship among village children, schooling, resources and opportunity becomes more direct here. The subject of the passage therefore concerns children's welfare; but children's experiences, a child's narrative perspective or the independent mental world of children does not become the organising centre. This is where the subtle but necessary distinction between children's literature and a social novel about children's concerns can be understood.

Through contrasts between Prem's family and the school environment, the author stresses the interconnectedness of education, livelihood and rural deprivation. The section gives the novel a social geography, although the introduction of numerous characters sometimes remains confined to explanatory sketches.

Part Three: Business, Friendship and the Beginnings of Trust

Prem's urban business, employees and office organisation provide the starting ground for this section. The arrival of Vidur from a poor village family transforms class distance into a personal relationship. Introduction, hospitality, dining together and respectful conduct bring into view the possibility of trust between people.

It is difficult to limit Prem's and Vidur's relationship to that of employer and dependant; the novelist tries to transform it into an ideal of friendship. Yet differences of economic power and social standing complicate this friendship from the beginning. What the characters regard as spontaneous

generosity may also be seen by the reader as containing disparities of dependence and entitlement.

The distinguishing feature of this section is that the seeds of a future dispute are sown in an atmosphere of warm welcome and trust. This is a highly effective transition in the development of events; the narrative's long-term tension is heightened by its early intimacy.

Part Four: The Priest, Prestige and Social Mediation

Introducing Pandit Kapileshwar Thakur, the story enters the intimate circle of religious standing, priest–patron relations, caste-based conduct and rural dominance. References to the character's humility and benevolence prevent him from becoming a one-dimensional villain, while the priest–patron relationship also provides subtle indications of social power.

The religious and economic relationships of the village do not occupy separate compartments. When decisions, access or social trust are established through a priest, an accepted tradition is at work behind them. The author searches for the values of humanity and cooperation within customary proprieties, but gives relatively little room to direct criticism of convention.

The discursive quality of dialogue is especially apparent here. Characters express ideas while going about their business; sometimes an idea sets events in motion, and sometimes the event merely illustrates an idea. In the latter case, artistic density is somewhat weakened.

Part Five: Rural and Urban Environments and Economic Life

This short part opens with the narrator's commentary upon differences between village and city environments. Comparisons among urban facilities, rural scarcity, collective life, employment, service and civic conduct come openly into view. Questions about material resources are combined with a moral assessment of society.

Prem's proposed loans, plans to obtain funds from a bank and the financial basis of village improvement give this passage particular importance. Assistance must not remain merely an exhortation; it requires finance, time, interest and management. The episode conveys that understanding. The genuine risks of raising capital and carrying debt, however, are not explored as extensively as they might be.

This part makes the programmatic undertone of the entire novel exceptionally clear. The critical question is how far the desire for social reform becomes an actual institutional mechanism and how far it remains dependent upon the protagonist's generosity.

Part Six: Vidur's Story and the Legal Conflict

Allegations brought against Prem and the examination of court-related documents provide this part's principal tension. The former warmth of his friendship with Vidur is repeatedly recalled; its contrast with present suspicion and antagonism heightens the sense of ‘betrayal’. Ownership of government

accommodation, notices, litigation and documents take the story beyond the bounds of the family into public institutions.

Ganguli Babu offers a contrasting figure of sympathetic counsel and legal understanding. He preserves the possibility of social trust against a world that might otherwise appear uniformly hostile. Several practical details of the litigation, however, are presented descriptively. This creates a legal atmosphere but raises the question of balance between documentary particulars and narrative excitement.

The author's particular insistence is that judicial truth should triumph. The entire affair imperils the protagonist's moral standing, but the opposing side's arguments are granted relatively little autonomy. The novel's social position is strong here, while its psychological multiplicity is limited.

Part Seven: Farmers' Fields and Signs of Rural Violence

Bhola Babu, Feku Raut and agricultural episodes open another world of labour relations in the village. Grazing animals, damaged crops, guarding fields, the conduct of a domineering person, apologies and an atmosphere of fear show that land is not simply a means of production but also a focus of prestige and conflict.

Despite indications of physical violence and bullying, the novelist emphasises individual judgement, religious trust and reform of conduct as means of resolution. The idea of farmers' political organisation or collective resistance remains comparatively faint. Greater freedom for labourers' own voices would have deepened the reader's understanding of class.

Reading the financial proposals of Part Five together with the agrarian experiences of Part Seven reveals the novel's central difficulty: goodwill can initiate development, but without altering the balance of power justice cannot be guaranteed.

Part Eight: Accusations, Offices and the Politics of Evidence

Company property, accounts, investigations and documents deepen Prem's predicament. Office episodes involving ‘Mr Khanna’ take the plot to a new level of realism through the processes of accusation and rebuttal. To establish his innocence, Prem must struggle with the language of administration.

The distinction between the authority of an office document and personal truth is particularly significant here. If a document is evidence of facts, it can also be misused; this dilemma is central to modern institutional life. The section accordingly moves beyond simple village–city comparisons to become a criticism of modern bureaucratic power.

The narrator's intense belief in the protagonist's innocence sometimes reduces dramatic uncertainty. Rather than merely learning the final outcome, the reader would welcome subtler descriptions of the process, humiliation and psychological injury.

Part Nine: Educated Youth, Women's Desires and Marriage

The narrative turns to Nayak, Kamini and Mr Darbala. Travel by train, books, studies, professional prospects and conversation produce the different rhythms of educated urban society. Kamini's intellectual ambitions and the question of marriage create an important subplot concerning women.

This passage offers an opportunity to regard love not simply as emotional attraction, but as a question of rights, consent, propriety and the choice of one's future. Kamini voices her wishes; nevertheless, the narrative arrangement repeatedly maintains the dominance of male characters' moral views. The subplot would have acquired greater dimensions had the woman's psychological conflicts been developed more fully from her own perspective.

This romantic branch appears to move away from the main story of village improvement, but it has a social function: the clash between education, urban careers and family propriety extends the novel's fundamental moral debate to another generation.

Part Ten: The Family, Celebration and the Testing of Personal Relationships

Kamini's birthday, the gathering of visitors and concern for Mr Darbala's health lend domestic life a human warmth at the beginning of this part. The atmosphere of celebration suddenly gives way to illness and anxiety. Such a change brings the instability of private life and the value of mutual care into view.

Between the surface happiness of relationships, underlying apprehensions, the authority of teacher and pupil or of different generations, and the difficulties of marital decisions, individuals choose their own moral responsibilities. The dialogue repeatedly tries to establish ideals; more attention to the characters' silence, embarrassment or self-contradiction would have made their experiences more credible.

Parts Nine and Ten together show that the author's social morality is not limited to public life: marriage and the family are another site of its testing.

Part Eleven: From Pilgrimage Experience to the Return

The final part begins with Banaras, the Vishwanath Temple, religious belief, travel away from home and sympathy for a person in distress. This religious geography connects the novel's village boundaries with a wider Indian cultural landscape. Helping a suffering person accords with the author's initial humanistic commitment.

In the closing pages, the strands involving Prem and Malti, Vidur, Manikant, Sulekha and family relationships come together again. The aspiration for village improvement remains alive through a balance between urban commerce and economic assistance to the village. The ending does not claim a complete political transformation; it rests upon hope generated through everyday conduct, trust and assistance.

The return at the end is meaningful. Where the opening journey was directed towards the village, the final journey reaffirms responsibility towards

it. The question nevertheless remains open: to what degree can moral goodwill eliminate complex social inequalities?

Principal Patterns of Social Criticism

Village and City: Interdependence Rather than Opposition

The introductory statement sharply contrasts urban prosperity with rural deprivation. In the story, however, Prem conducts his business in the city while his goal of improvement lies in the village: material resources are acquired in one place and their social use is sought in another. Village and city are therefore not enemy worlds but two ends of an interdependent economic system. This complicates the novel's declared moral opposition. To regard the city solely as the centre of greed and the village solely as a pure collectivity would be exaggerations in both cases; readers witness the tension between these concepts.

Prem's journeys are not merely changes of location but movements of social consciousness. Railway stations, hotels, offices, fields and courtyards are different stages within a single narrative territory. Through these changes of scene, the author creates a portrait of displacement in modern Mithila, migrant livelihoods and the incomplete provision of village amenities.

Class Responsibility, Charity and Structural Change

Prem's philanthropy is deeply well-intentioned. Nevertheless, the position of characters receiving assistance from someone with economic power calls for a critical testing of the author's idealism. If village transformation depends upon the loans, service, instruction or moral inspiration of one capable protagonist, how far does the village community develop its own independent social power? The novel's class question resides precisely here.

The role of loans in rural development, risks faced by farmers, crop protection, access to schooling and access to justice are interwoven concerns. Reform cannot therefore be merely the fruit of individual virtue; it requires collective decision-making, transparent finance, legal protection and accountability in local institutions. By this standard the author's vision is inspiring but, in places, incomplete.

Caste, Religion and Social Hierarchy

The author's statement clearly aspires to oppose caste hostility and communal narrowness. The coexistence of priests, prosperous villagers, teachers and cultivators affords glimpses of social hierarchy. Caste experience, however, does not receive extensive treatment through the memories, language and struggles of the people who suffer from it. An exhortation to social harmony and an analysis of the power of the caste system are not the same. Acknowledging the difference does not diminish the humanistic intention of the work; it identifies its historical limits.

The Judiciary and Documentary Truth

Episodes involving lawsuits, notices, affidavits, office property, allegations and evidence are important aspects of modern social reality. Inequalities of economic power may prove decisive not just in the fields but also in courts and offices. Through the accusation against Prem, the novel raises questions about the destruction of personal reputation and the impartiality of institutions. Its account of the courts, however, sometimes becomes excessively explanatory while acquainting the reader with procedural complexities.

Women Characters: From Companionship to the Struggle for Autonomy

Malti is an important centre of domestic life, practices of social help and Prem's psychological strength. Sulekha and Sunita bring their own network of relationships into the family. Kamini's story introduces the questions of education, professional identity and marital choice. Despite this extensive presence, most decisive public plans remain controlled by male characters. This is a gender-based limitation of the novel.

Kamini's story in particular shows that an educated woman's aspirations cannot be reduced to her suitability for marriage; she makes claims upon her own desires and future. The narrator nevertheless grants her less space for autonomy than the story might have allowed. A critique of patriarchal relations is possible from within the novel itself; there is no need to impose an external theory upon it.

Narrative Craft, Dialogue, Language and the Symbolism of the Title

The Strengths and Difficulties of a Multi-Centred Plot

The extended narrative's first achievement is the breadth of its fictional society. Moving outwards from Prem and Malti to Vidur, Manikant and Sulekha, the village priest, farmers, office workers, Nayak and Kamini, and pilgrims, the story connects different social locations. Yet the transitions from one character's life to another's are not equally strong throughout. Some subplots move away from the main developmental arc and begin to resemble independent moral novels.

The numbered parts offer readers pauses within the work as a whole. Sometimes a part ends with a momentary emotional resolution; elsewhere a new story arises without sufficient preparation. The strength of this arrangement is its panoramic portrayal of life; its weakness is looseness and narrative repetition.

Dialogue-Driven Prose: Living Speech or Sermon?

Dialogue establishes the characters' closeness to one another. Questions and answers, forms of address, apologies, advice and reassurance allow readers to encounter many shades of rural and urban conduct. In several places, however, dialogue conveys the author's moral opinions more than individual character. The voices then cease to be sufficiently distinguishable. This applies particularly to Prem's speeches about social improvement and to certain episodes of conflict resolution.

The use of moral ideas as narrative turning points is itself a novelistic tradition. Artistic strength grows, however, when ideas arise naturally out of characters' actions, failures, hesitation or mistaken decisions. In Anathiya Kukur, the successful episodes are those in which economic choices have observable consequences; the weaker ones are those in which, rather than showing outcomes, the narration begins to explain the virtue it wishes to commend.

Linguistic Register and the Possibilities of Editing

Colloquial Maithili, social forms of address, bureaucratic vocabulary, contemporary terms relating to trains and offices, and religious diction coexist in the text. This increases the diversity of its social world. At the same time, consistent spelling and punctuation across such a multilingual vocabulary would aid reading. In a future critical edition, editorial consistency in character names, dialogue marks, episode divisions and technical terms would be valuable.

The vitality of the language comes from its local cadence. Editing should aim not to dissolve that cadence into Hindi or any external standard, but to communicate the author's own idiom and the distinct voices of characters more clearly to readers.

The Possible Meanings of the Title Anathiya Kukur

The image of the ‘kukur’, or dog, in the title may be read as a metaphor for social conduct. The author's opening statement expresses concern over urban attractions, the grip of self-interest, the weakening of village relationships and opportunism; the story itself contains broken trust, plunder, deception and threats to public standing. In the light of these episodes, the title may be understood as a satirical sign of society's unrestrained self-interest.

It would nevertheless be inappropriate to assign the title a single certain etymology or to presume it names one particular character within the story. Its metaphorical power matters also because the work is not a simple animal story but an ethical struggle involving human relationships.

Comparative Position within the Maithili Tradition of Children's Literature

The mere appearance of children, discussion of schools or a commitment to educational reform does not make a work children's literature. One must separately consider the intended readership, narrative viewpoint, linguistic pace, imagination, age-appropriate complexity and centre of experience. Extended litigation, business loans, land disputes, married life and the complexities of adult love are central narrative elements of Anathiya Kukur. Its primary readership is therefore that of the adult social novel.

The organisation of Videha's ‘Shishu Utsav’ collection makes clear that Maithili children's literature is not confined to moral fables. It lists distinct forms, including nursery songs, children's poetry, short-short stories, picture stories, children's novels, plays, popular presentations of science and translated

illustrated books. Children's writing in Maithili is thus being brought together digitally in genres that can be compared with one another.

Videha's list mentions 2002 as the year of the first edition of Preeti Thakur's translated Chhot Aa Paigh and 2003 for Mal-Jal Aa Janwar Dis Dekhu. Listings for Gonu Jha Aa Aan Maithili Chitrakatha (2008), Maithili Chitrakatha (2009), Mithilak Lokdevta (2010) and Vidyapatik Purush Pariksha (2012) illustrate a sequence of picture stories and adaptations of folk memory and classical narratives for children. These dates belong to the relevant catalogue entries; they cannot, by themselves, establish chronological primacy or the full history of Maithili children's literature.

Videha classifies Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Nai Dharaiye and Jagadanand Jha 'Manu''s Chonha as children's novels; Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand''s Swarna Kamal is also expressly listed as a children's novel. By contrast, Anathiya Kukur is placed in the general novel category. The most dependable comparative fact here is not similarity of subject but the catalogue's explicit distinction of genre. Swarna Kamal establishes the writer's interest in child readers, while Anathiya Kukur extends the same writer's adult social narrative.

Neeta Jha's children's short-story collection Bilai Mausi, Munnaji's Teen Ta Bal Natak and Preeti Thakur's picture-story undertaking demonstrate generic diversity in writing for children. No definite judgement is offered here about the particular characters or literary quality of all these works, because the evidence for comparison is their published catalogue entries, not a line-by-line comparative reading of all the original books. These generic facts may nevertheless legitimately be used in describing the tradition.

A history of children's literature cannot adequately represent folk tales, oral traditions, nursery songs, school literature, children's novels and digital picture stories as a single linear development. They differ in reading age, textual culture, distribution and artistic expectations. Anathiya Kukur's commitment to rural education enters into conversation with the social conditions of children, but the novel is not a primary object in the history of children's literature; it is a neighbouring object of study within social prose.

Position in Relation to the Author's Other Works

Videha's book list describes Gaam-Ghar as a story collection; Sujata, Gudari Ke Lal and Sukanya as novels; Aadambar as a story collection; Dillik Park as word portraits; Parivar as an autobiographically inflected novel; and Swarna Kamal as a children's novel. The list demonstrates the range of prose genres practised by the writer. Anathiya Kukur's interest in movement between city and village, family, employment and moral conflict is usefully situated within this broader literary career.

A title alone, however, cannot establish thematic similarity or a relationship of influence. Gaam-Ghar, for example, suggests rural subjects, but without reading its constituent stories one cannot declare concrete similarities between their characters and those of Anathiya Kukur. Criticism must acknowledge the limits of inference. The findings of this study rest principally

upon the printed text of Anathiya Kukur itself and, where it compares the author's other writings, upon Videha's verified bibliography.

Critical Assessment: Achievements and Limitations

The work's first achievement is the breadth of the novelist's social concerns. Prem and Malti's private family life is not the whole story: it extends to poor farmers, teachers, priests, urban employees, accused persons, lawyers and courts, educated young women and pilgrims. The economic and ethical questions of Maithil life become interconnected through this range.

A second achievement is that village reform is related not merely to emotional sympathy, but to financial transactions, employment, loans, land disputes and legal protection. Its realistic perspective thus becomes concrete in several places. A third achievement is the easy movement of dialogue, which allows readers to experience both the intimacy of characters and the collapse of trust between them.

An important limitation is the repetition of moral idealism. Prem's goodness is sometimes so decisive that the independent depth of other characters' motives and uncertainties is reduced. If the mental lives of the more antagonistic figures were opened further, the social conflict would gain in dramatic contradiction.

A second limitation is the unevenness of narrative focus. The romantic subplot involving the young, while valuable in its own right, requires a more coherent integration into the principal village–city axis. A third limitation is the restricted role of women in decisive action. Malti and Kamini matter, but many social outcomes are organised around the proposals and decisions of men. A fourth limitation is the excessive trust placed in individual generosity as a remedy for social structure.

Even after these criticisms, it would be unjust to dismiss Anathiya Kukur as merely sermonising prose. Its everyday social world, linguistic environment, family ties, crises of the modern office and sincere aspiration for village improvement raise distinctive questions within the Maithili social novel. Literary assessment must respect these social aspirations while subjecting their artistic realisation to rigorous scrutiny.

Conclusion

Anathiya Kukur is a Maithili novel centred upon social responsibility, animated by the belief that human cooperation can bridge the distance between village and city. Prem and Malti's life, the deterioration of the relationship with Vidur, farmers' insecurity, documentary forms of justice and the younger generation's emotional struggles are not separate debates. Together they ask what relations among trust, propriety, wealth and justice ought to look like in modern society.

The work appears to have been written in the hope that much may be achieved by improving individual moral conduct. Socially this hope matters; artistically it becomes a limitation when complex structural conditions are

reduced to a conclusion of easy goodwill. The novel's actual contribution emerges more clearly when read through this contradiction.

Within the development of Maithili children's literature, its place is not that of a children's novel but of adult social writing that raises serious questions about educational opportunities and children's futures. The separate generic identity of the author's Swarna Kamal makes the distinction clearer. An inquiry that maintains it is more credible both as literary history and as textual criticism.

Chapter 5

Sujata

Women's Identity, Social Control and Administrative Ethics

Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’’s Sujata is a short novel in which the heroine's private life is intertwined with social and administrative life. The narrative begins with family arrangements for marriage, moves through widowhood, the question of remarriage and livelihood, and develops in its latter part through episodes of office malpractice, the exploitation of women employees and resistance. This research essay reads the thirteen numbered parts separately and evaluates character construction, the narrator's moral position, the social psychology of Mithila, linguistic conventions, visual detail, dialogue and the conclusion. Comparison with the history of Maithili children's literature clarifies that Sujata is not itself a children's novel, although its themes of education, agency, gender equality and institutional justice offer separate possibilities for adaptation for adolescent readers. The essay cites only the printed original and specified literary archival materials from Videha.

Bibliographic Description and Genre

The title page explicitly describes Sujata as a ‘Maithili novel’. Its author is Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’, and the publisher is named as Mrs Amal Devi of Bhikhanpur, Bhagalpur. The dedication names Shri Amaresh Chandra Mishra. The signed introduction by Dr Amarnath bears the printed date 7 January 2006. No separate, definite year of first publication could be confirmed in the original copy available; to treat the date of the introduction as the publication year would therefore be unjustified in textual criticism. The original narrative runs from printed page 1 to page 80 and is divided into thirteen numbered parts.

Genre is a foundational issue in this criticism. The characters are principally adults, and the narrative centres upon marriage, social pressure related to financial exchanges resembling dowry, public attitudes linked to sexual morality, widows' remarriage, livelihood, employee politics, misconduct and relationships between senior officials and employees. The child-centred viewpoint, leadership by child characters, unfolding of events appropriate to children's psychology and age-specific narrative style expected in a children's novel are not its organising creative principles. Videha's children's literature list classifies the author's Swarna Kamal as a ‘children's novel’, while its prose

list separately classifies Sujata as a ‘novel’. That distinction is itself important evidence.

The introduction discusses the author's poetic interests and reformist outlook. In his preliminary statement, the author says the story is based on true events while names of people and places have been fictionalised. That is the author's own claim within the novel's paratext, not independent historical verification. What matters for the critic is that the author presents the story as a record of moral struggle even before it begins. Consequently, the reader's sympathies are already being organised in Sujata's favour.

The Critical Problem and Principal Arguments

A fundamental question arises: does the social consciousness of Sujata achieve the artistic form of a novel, or does the author's reformist purpose sometimes overwhelm the complexity of characters and events? The answer has two sides. The successive experiences of the heroine—education, marriage, bereavement, the possibility of remarriage, efforts to end economic dependence and an awareness of rights at work—create a living representation of social reality through their development. Yet the sharp moral division of characters, repeated negative portrayals of villains, didactic dialogue and the swift administrative resolution of problems at the end also simplify the narrative.

Three levels are kept distinct in this study: first, events or words explicitly present in the book; second, critical interpretations derived from that text; and third, comparative facts drawn from Videha's catalogues and research articles on Maithili children's literature. The fictional narrative is not treated as independent history, nor is the mere appearance of a title in a bibliography taken as proof of the work's entire plot. Episodes can be checked against the original printed page numbers.

Overall Narrative Development: From Private Grief to Public Resistance

The story begins with Ramakant's family life and preparations for the marriage of his son Pankaj. While pursuing his studies, Pankaj secures a government job. Sujata, meanwhile, is born into Umakant's family, where, despite poverty, she learns to balance study, household responsibilities and social dignity. Amid discussions of a marriage proposal and economic standing, the two are married. Their early married life is represented as a kind of hopeful middle-class dream, extended through travel scenes and mutual affection.

The first major turning point is Pankaj's premature death. Sujata's life is suddenly thrown into crisis. Her parents-in-law, her own parents, society's prejudices concerning widowhood, fears of humiliation and economic anxieties all press upon her at once. Sujata raises questions concerning her desires and rights, but her decisions are not straightforward: family pressure, fear of public disgrace, self-respect and the practical demands of living collide. Bereavement ultimately pushes her towards self-reliance.

The government office then becomes the second principal setting. Under provisions associated with Pankaj's employment, Sujata obtains an opportunity to work. As a new employee, she encounters bureaucracy, paperwork, networks among staff and improper conduct. Through Kalavati, Sunita, a character described as a leader, personnel officers and senior officials, the story transforms a crisis of private life into a question of institutional injustice. The final phase indicates the possibility of change through personal courage, collective assistance and administrative intervention.

Separate Close Readings of the Thirteen Numbered Parts

Part One: Family, Male Succession and Marriage Preparations

The story opens amidst the month of Phagun, village sounds and household activity. Colourful seasonal description gives the text emotional ease. Ramakant's middle-class family, his son Pankaj's studies and successful employment, and concern about his marriage together establish a social structure in which marriage is not simply a private bond between two individuals but also a matter of family status and plans for the future.

Repeated discussion of Pankaj's education, job and income discloses the link between material security and the marriage market. References to 'good' employment, family qualifications and a balanced domestic life clarify this class mentality. Critically significant is the fact that marriage is initially defined by the man's achievements; the heroine has yet to appear. That delay subsequently makes Sujata's centrality more meaningful.

Part Two: Sujata's Childhood, Labour and Education

This part introduces Sujata's family and upbringing. The material shortages in Umakant's household, farming and limited resources provide an essential basis for the narrative. From childhood Sujata is portrayed as studious, well-mannered and capable in household tasks. The double burden of formal education and domestic labour is an important sign of the social formation of women.

On one hand the author regards a daughter's education as an achievement; on the other, he also seeks proof of her exemplary character in service to her family, religious feeling and social approval. The tension between empowerment and the conventional ideal of womanhood must be recognised here. Rather than limiting Sujata's abilities to a list of virtues belonging to a 'good daughter', one can regard her knowledge and work as an independent foundation beyond the expectations of the marriage market.

Part Three: The Economics of Marriage, Negotiation and Class Culture

Negotiations over Pankaj's marriage intersect with the family's financial limitations. Discussion moves among the wedding procession, available means, expenditure, the ideal marriage and practical requirements of prestige. Ramakant speaks in favour of an ideal opposed to ostentation, but family standing, fear of public opinion and concern for the other side complicate social conduct.

The real achievement here lies in representing marriage not as a pure event of love but as a field of social rank, property, family self-respect and public opinion. The characters' exchanges, however, sometimes begin to resemble speeches at a meeting, reducing the naturalness of dialogue. From a modern critical perspective, the section combines opposition to the commodification of marriage with a didactic narrative technique.

Part Four: The Post-Wedding Journey, Love and Approaching Separation

After the wedding, the episodes of the chauthi observance, travel, meetings and affection between Pankaj and Sujata bring readers close to private life. Scenic detail and marital intimacy give Sujata an opportunity to become an experiencing person, rather than merely a symbol of a social question. Behind the celebrations and arrangements for the wedding, the uncertainty of the couple's private life is also present.

The emotional movement of travel, descriptions of beauty and idealisation of love are presumably intended to intensify the sorrow to come. Nevertheless, the psychological depth of the couple's personal conversations is somewhat limited; love is established more through the narrator's comments than through subtle conflicts within the characters themselves. This part forms a bridge between the novel's emotional setting and the crisis towards which the narrative moves.

Part Five: Domestic Intimacy and Fragile Happiness

The story depicts the daily life of the newly married couple, Pankaj's office, Sujata's management of the household and their care for each other. The narrator offers small practical details; happiness is consequently expressed through habitual actions as well as through emotional declarations.

The part's brevity is important to the plot. Happiness seems threatened with destruction even before it can become settled. Sujata's personality abounds in service, affection and responsibility, but the independent development of her own wishes and thoughts remains limited. Widowhood in the following part calls that imbalance into question.

Part Six: Pankaj's Death, Grief and the Institutional Forms of Insecurity

Pankaj's sudden death turns the story decisively. After an episode involving travel, news of his death, family sorrow, Sujata's helpless position and anxiety over livelihood are presented together. The author does not reduce grief to a pathetic tableau; he also reveals how fragile women's security is in a social order dependent upon husbands.

Advice about Sujata's future, the support of her parents, her parents-in-law's reactions and interventions by others reveal contrasting moral positions. Some characters invoke religion and convention to present restrictions on a widow's life as natural. The critical question is which voice carries greater force: the widow's own suffering or society's control over her life. Sujata's voice is suppressed at first, but that suppression creates the need for later resistance.

Part Seven: Widows' Remarriage, Women's Rights and Society's Double Standards

The narrator directly comments on the male-dominated nature of society. A widower's remarriage is socially accepted as normal, while a widow's possibility of remarriage is surrounded by condemnation, family prestige and the threat of social punishment. Through this contrast, the narrator makes gender justice a central debate of the novel.

The strength of this part lies in the clarity of its public reasoning. Its weakness is that the narrator's definitive moral statements sometimes diminish the many layers of the characters' inner lives. Even so, relating economic and emotional insecurity to society's moral pressures is an important intervention within the reformist tradition of Maithili social fiction.

Part Eight: Proposals for Remarriage, Kinship Politics and Freedom of Choice

Lutti Jha's intervention, tensions within household relationships, episodes involving Naresh and Ramesh, and conversations among the families make this a dialogue-driven part. Competing interests arise over who has the right to decide a woman's future within the institution of marriage. Affectionate language, fear of damaged prestige, self-interest, public opinion and charity as a disguise become intertwined.

The danger is to interpret the heroine's rights simply as the possibility of being ‘accepted by someone’. The novel attempts to escape this danger as Sujata's disagreement and need to make her own decision emerge. Male intermediaries nonetheless occupy substantial space. The story favours women's independence, yet the social recognition of that independence still appears dependent on the support of male relatives.

Part Nine: Entry into Employment and the Social Meaning of White Clothing

Following Pankaj's death, Sujata obtains a job through official procedures. Her appearance at the office in white garments on the first day makes private grief publicly visible. The part marks her transition from the roles of wife and widow to that of employee. The centre of social identity moves from home to office.

Employment here means more than earnings; it offers the ability to make decisions about everyday life, personal identity, public participation and hope for the future. The responses of officials and other employees to her appointment, however, make clear that a woman's presence in public space does not in itself create safety. A second struggle begins in Sujata's experience.

Part Ten: Kalavati and the Informal Foundations of Solidarity

Sujata meets Kalavati at the office. This relationship opens the possibility of cooperation among women within administrative procedures. Documents, colleagues, systems of assistance and employees' problems are presented not as mysterious obstacles but as concrete forms of social structure.

In the novel's first half, the family was the centre of decisions about life; now relationships of trust are sought among colleagues. Sujata no longer regards her difficulties merely as personal fate, but understands them as a question of shared circumstances. The part's importance lies not in a miraculous turn of the plot, but in generating the possibility of collective action.

Part Eleven: Employee Politics, Improper Demands and the Strategy of Courage

Against arbitrary power, Sujata does not seek direct physical force; she looks for argument, evidence, colleagues' advice and the proper official procedure.

Critically, this section may be read as a short narrative of institutional ethics. The story shows that personal goodwill is necessary but insufficient for resisting injustice: documents, the confidence of colleagues and knowledge of the hierarchy of office are also essential. Its impact would nevertheless have been greater had the psychology of corrupt characters been more complex.

Part Twelve: Contacting Senior Officials and Reordering Relations of Power

Having learned about the senior personnel officer, Sujata attempts to bring the problem of office injustice to a higher level. Her personal courage becomes a process of administrative communication. A path is sought among the human sensitivity of the official, the pressures faced by office employees and the causes of misconduct.

Here the story locates its instrument of resolution in the ethical judgement of a fair-minded senior officer. This optimism is welcome from a human standpoint, but a realistic study of institutional reform raises a question: should justice depend solely upon a ‘good senior sahib’? A clearer treatment of written complaints, impartial investigations, protection of rights and disciplinary procedures would have made the narrative more credible.

Part Thirteen: Sunita, Exposure, Collective Resistance and the Ending

In the final and longest part, Sunita's experience brings a second story of women's vulnerability. Sujata witnesses her suffering and resolves to offer help on the basis of her own experience.

As Kalavati, Sunita, Kamala, the personnel officer and other employees become involved, the problem crosses the boundary of one woman confronting one man and becomes a matter of public responsibility. In the conclusion, the officer's support and a decision concerning the transfer of an offending employee produce a sense of moral victory. Critically, however, it is necessary to observe that a transfer is not, in itself, final justice for exploitation; questions of accountability and prevention in the future remain.

The scope of this final part provides literary evidence that the narrative's actual concern is no longer limited to widows' remarriage. Women's public agency, safety at work and opposition to corruption become major creative purposes. The story ends optimistically, but readers can also discern indications of the justice system's incompleteness.

A Sociological Study of the Heroine and Supporting Characters

Sujata: From the Image of an Ideal Woman to a Citizen Who Decides for Herself

The author initially constructs Sujata according to social ideals of good conduct, education, domestic competence and beauty. Rather than challenging the traditional idea of the 'good daughter', the narrator initially relies upon that value. Later, entering employment, resisting humiliation, standing up for other women and daring to speak to an official transform her identity. Through this development, the heroine's humanity moves from personal endurance to a public consciousness of justice.

Sujata's intimate mental state, however, is not revealed with equal depth throughout. Her moral decisions are often announced as ideals; more space for doubt, self-contradiction, the bodily sensations of fear and internal uncertainty would have made the character more many-sided in literary terms. This criticism does not diminish her courage; it distinguishes the novel's achievements from its limitations.

Pankaj, Ramakant and the Parents: Affection and Patriarchal Order

Pankaj's job and marriage become elements of family prestige. His premature death functions as both an emotional catalyst and a dividing line within the narrative. The conduct of adult men, including Ramakant, is not uniform; some express affection, assistance and moral responsibility. Nevertheless, men's opinions, permissions and social standing continue to influence decisions about women's lives. This contradiction shows that the presence of 'good men' does not automatically abolish patriarchal structures.

Lutti Jha, Naresh and Ramesh: Interests, Conventions and Mediation

Lutti Jha is an important voice of household politics and competing interests; his conduct reveals the complexity of kinship, social anxieties and self-interest. The episodes involving Naresh and Ramesh acquaint readers with different levels of possibility, support and obstruction surrounding remarriage. Yet the author places some individuals within a stark good–bad opposition; developing the social origins, contradictions and possibility of change within antagonistic conduct would have produced a more substantial group of characters.

Kalavati and Sunita: The Expansion of Women's Solidarity

The decisive link through which the heroine's individual story becomes a social novel is her relationship with Kalavati and Sunita. Although these women face distinct crises, their circumstances are connected to a shared structure of power. The help Sujata gives is not merely philanthropy; it begins in the mutual recognition of suffering and develops towards collective resistance. These characters' independent awareness and personal histories are not developed as fully as the heroine's, however, and they often serve to clarify the main plot's moral purpose.

Narrative Technique, Time, Setting and Language

Chronology and the Structure of the Thirteen Parts

The story is broadly linear: childhood and education, marriage, death, social crisis, employment, institutional struggle and resolution. The division into thirteen parts is a device for organising the text. They are not autonomous chapters with conventional descriptive titles, but smaller units centred upon turns in the sequence of events. Part Five is relatively brief and Part Thirteen particularly extensive. This asymmetry reveals the narrative's emotional direction: more space is reserved for resisting injustice than for the happiness of marriage.

Village, Home, Pilgrimage and Office

Village agriculture, domestic arrangements, festive wedding venues, scenes of travel and the urban office are not mere backdrops; they express the story's value systems. Family and public opinion prevail in the village, status at the wedding, private aspiration in travel and official rank in the workplace. Sujata's journey crosses the boundaries of these places. The early village portrayal is sensory, while the office episodes depend more on conversation, anxiety and plans. This movement from scene to idea is both a distinctive narrative feature and an artistic imbalance.

Narratorial Intervention and Maxims

The third-person narrator generally adopts an omniscient perspective. Rather than merely recounting a person's conduct, the narrator also offers an immediate ethical assessment of it. Criticism of male-dominated society, advocacy of the ideal marriage and exposition of workplace propriety exemplify such intervention. In terms of social change, this approach provides readers with a clear orientation of values; from the standpoint of literary ambiguity, it sometimes restricts their freedom to judge for themselves.

The Density of Maithili Dialogue and Editorial Questions

The book is rich in spoken Maithili, rural and middle-class vocabulary, conventions of address and naturally arranged conversations. Common verbal forms and relational words such as ‘bajalathi’, ‘muda’, ‘katek’, ‘okara’ and ‘hamra’ root readers in its linguistic setting. Yet in didactic episodes, characters from different social positions begin to offer lengthy moral arguments in the same manner. Future editorial work on the text would benefit from attention to punctuation, printing errors, separation of dialogue and sentence construction—not from careless standardisation of its original word forms.

Feminist, Class-Based and Institutional Readings

A feminist assessment of the novel should not stop at the observation that ‘Sujata is courageous’. Three distinct forms of power need to be recognised: familial control over marriage and widowhood; men's traditional dominance over economic resources; and abuse of official authority in the workplace.

Sujata's journey demands the right to personal decision-making in the first two areas and the moral rights of citizenship in the third.

This understanding of justice is not an ultimate model of fully modern feminist autonomy. At the outset, Sujata's 'ideal' conduct seems to need validation through domestic service, propriety and modesty. This qualified idealisation prompts the question: why must service, purity and social acceptance always be prerequisites for being considered a respectable woman? Sujata's rights are not a reward for moral excellence, but rights she possesses as a human being. This interpretative distinction opens the text more fully.

At the level of class, Sujata's struggle takes her from a family without adequate resources to the security of government employment. Education, public appointment and documentary literacy become means of social mobility; yet recruitment, posting, workplace networks and abuse of authority present economic inequality in new forms. The novel stresses the practical constraints faced by poor and middle-class households, but does not develop the extensive structure of labour institutions or independent organisations of women employees.

The question of institutional justice demands particular attention at the end. The positive resolution offers readers confidence that evidence and courage can challenge injustice. Nevertheless, making justice dependent upon a single senior official's goodwill does not remove institutional opacity. Complaint procedures, protection for harassed women, accountability of the guilty and collective oversight remain matters for criticism beyond the work itself. Even with this limitation, Sujata is noteworthy for raising the question of administrative ethics.

Linguistic Examples and Their Interpretation

The following brief extracts correspond to the page numbers in the original printed edition. Quotations are kept within evidentiary limits; no lengthy, unclear or ambiguous passages have been quoted simply for the sake of including them. Their interpretation is a critical commentary separate from the words of the quotations.

Original Extract	Printed Page	Critical Significance
"The month of Phagun was passing."	1	Seasonal description establishes the emotional landscape of rural life.
"Sujata was skilled in household tasks as well."	6	An initial ideal that treats domestic labour alongside education as a

Original Extract	Printed Page	Critical Significance
		feminine virtue.
"Our society is male-dominated."	29	The narrator's direct criticism of social gender relations.
"Dressed in white, Sujata arrived at the office."	44	The visible sign of widowhood marks a new entry into the public workplace.
"One day at the office Sujata met Sunita."	66	The beginning of a new episode involving women's solidarity and institutional injustice.

Particular attention should be given to the evidentiary character of the quotations. They are textual evidence from this particular work; they do not automatically establish the historical truth of all the story's social claims. A sentence on printed page 29 may signal the narrator's overall consciousness, but its actual significance becomes clear when the surrounding argument on that page is read as well.

Comparative Position in the Historical Development of Maithili Children's Literature

When writing a history of children's literature, it is misleading to classify a work as children's writing solely because its language is 'simple' or it conveys a 'moral message'. The age of its readership, independent action by child characters, narrative curiosity, use of images, oral qualities, psychological capacities of readers and experience of childhood are all important criteria. Sujata contains episodes about education in childhood, but the decisive connection for readers is with an adult woman's legal and social rights and the power exercised in offices. It is therefore more appropriate to place it alongside adult social novels, while regarding it as a possible source of themes adjacent to children's literature, than to include it directly in the history of children's novels.

Videha's archives of literature for children and adolescents reveal a broad generic environment for Maithili writing for the young: children's songs and poetry, folktales, children's novels, picture stories, translations, scientific writing and contemporary adolescent fiction. The available list explicitly includes Jagadanand Jha 'Manu"s Chonha, Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Nai Dharaiye, Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand"s Swarna Kamal, Preeti Thakur's Gonu Jha Aa Aan Maithili Chitrakatha, Devanshu Vats's Natasha and Dr Ramanand

Jha ‘Raman’’s translated picture series Raju Aa Takak Gaachh. The list documents a literary current; the appearance of titles alone cannot establish a complete year-by-year publication history.

The development of children's literature may be understood in terms of at least four tendencies: narrative foundations inherited from folktales and oral tradition; children's songs and writing for ethical instruction; language practice and social curiosity through picture stories, translations and children's novels; and quizzes, audiovisual forms, thematic stories and adolescent debates in contemporary digital media. Videha's archive attests to their coexistence. It would be inappropriate to regard these tendencies as rigid chronological ‘first, second and third’ phases, since many were active simultaneously.

Two Generic Horizons of One Writer: Swarna Kamal and Sujata

Videha identifies Swarna Kamal as Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’’s children's novel, while both Sujata's original title page and Videha's prose catalogue identify Sujata as an ordinary Maithili novel. This demonstrates the writer's creative range. Without separate examination of the complete text of Swarna Kamal, however, one cannot make detailed claims about its plot, characters or final evaluation. The criterion of comparison here is genre: in Sujata, the agency of an adult heroine becomes social and administrative resistance; in a children's novel, the readerly presentation of these questions would have to change in accordance with children's experiences, curiosity and capacity to decide.

Picture Stories, Folk Narratives and the Contemporary Children's Novel

Videha's catalogue provides indications of Preeti Thakur's original picture-story endeavours in 2008–2009 and numerous entries in the tradition of translated picture stories. Children's novels by writers such as Jagadanand Jha ‘Manu’ and Jagdish Prasad Mandal, as well as listings of adolescent stories in modern digital publishing, indicate a tendency to present literary material for different reading levels through distinct media. Against this background, Sujata's arguments about education and self-respect could become material for adolescent fiction, but in its present form the stigma associated with widowhood and the complex power structure of offices are not organised as a child-centred narrative.

Possibilities and Precautions for Adaptation for Young Readers

If an adaptation of Sujata were ever prepared for adolescent readers, its principal educational elements would be girls' education, criticism of prejudice against widows, self-reliance, organised cooperation among women and the importance of complaints, evidence and judicial procedure. Such an adaptation would require a child-centred perspective, age-sensitive treatment, agency for characters, comprehensible presentation of complex workplace incidents and a non-sensational account of violence and harassment. Simply labelling the original novel ‘children's literature’ and undertaking a carefully considered child-friendly rewriting are different enterprises.

'Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra', published in Videha issue 447, presents comparative criteria for appropriateness to child readers, rasa, folk foundations and children's agency. Using those criteria within their proper limits clarifies Sujata's distinctive character: the focus is not children's agency but the civic agency of an adult woman. Acknowledging the distinction does not diminish the work; it makes the history of literary genres more exact.

Achievements, Contradictions and Limitations

The principal achievement is that the novel does not treat women's economic dependence merely as a subject for sentimental pity. By bringing together education, government employment, risks at work and collective resistance, it presents a concrete structure of social injustice. Second, Sujata's story extends from the domestic threshold to the public office; this breadth gives several layers to its representation of social reality. Third, Maithili dialogue and the family-centred vernacular reinforce the work's cultural distinctiveness.

There are four principal limitations. First, the clear moral division between an ideal heroine and negative characters restricts their complexity. Second, the narrator's comments sometimes announce in advance meanings that could emerge from events and dialogue. Third, while advocating women's freedom, the story periodically validates their respectability according to conventional modesty. Fourth, the outcome of administrative reform comes to rest too quickly upon the goodwill of a senior official. Yet these limitations do not render the work's social debate irrelevant; they provide grounds for critical rereading.

In effect, Sujata debates a historical transition: will society regard women's rights merely as an object of 'sympathy', or as a principle requiring change in civic arrangements and social institutions? Sujata's courage provides an initial answer. Contemporary readers will also seek another answer: a safe complaint system, disciplinary accountability, durable structures of support among women and institutional arrangements for equal opportunities.

Conclusion

To call Sujata merely a story about widows' remarriage would omit the broader social significance of its latter half; to call it merely a story against corruption would marginalise its earlier treatment of education, marriage arrangements and widowhood. Its creative unity lies in these two strands: self-determination born of private grief becomes a public consciousness of justice. At first Sujata is society's approved 'ideal woman', but by the end she acquires not merely endurance but an active capacity for resistance and cooperation.

The novel combines social realism, reformist argument and women's civic identity. Its artistry is not equally mature throughout—dramatic conflicts, psychological layers and institutional complexity need fuller development in several places. Even so, in the study of Maithili prose the work raises important questions extending from women's social position to ethics in the workplace.

Its relation to the history of children's literature is not one of direct generic membership but of a comparative boundary encompassing ideas such as education, self-respect, equality and social responsibility. Reading it with that boundary clearly in view presents its actual literary value more accurately.

Chapter 6

Sukanya

Widow Remarriage, Women's Identity and Social Change

An Extended Text-Based Critical Study of Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand''s Maithili Novel

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand''s Sukanya (2019) is a work of Maithili social fiction that relates widow remarriage not merely to personal happiness or the arrangements of a household, but to social recognition, women's dignity, freedom of choice and communal justice. The narrative begins with Ratan's widowerhood and the prospect of companionship returning to his life; Sukanya's experience of widowhood, education and social humiliation invests that prospect with a wider significance. Kamlesh's supportive role, the moral dilemmas of parents and guardians, the episode involving Rinki and Nirmal, Raghuwansh Babu's resistance to convention, and the subsequent events concerning Sewakram, Vishal and Suman extend the story from personal acquaintance to a movement within the community. Drawing on the work's original printed pages, this study examines the development of the plot, the benefits and limitations of its structure, its feminist possibilities, the naturalness of its dialogue, and the tension between idealistic solutions and social reality. A thematic comparison with Kanyadan and Paro helps establish points of continuity and change in the Maithili novel's treatment of women's lives.

The Work and the Scope of the Study

The title page of Sukanya identifies the work as a 'Maithili novel'. Its author is Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'; its publisher is Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Uparadaha, Darbhanga; its year of publication is 2019; and its stated price is 150 rupees. At the beginning of the book are 'A Few Words of My Own' by Shri Phoolchandra Mishra 'Raman' and the author's own prefatory statement. The principal narrative occupies printed pages 1–90. These details derive from the book's publication information and preliminary matter.

In his foreword, Shri Phoolchandra Mishra 'Raman' identifies widow remarriage as the work's central subject. The author likewise discusses changing social circumstances surrounding marriage: mismatched marriages, the insecurity of widowhood, familial resistance and the wish to establish a household anew. Together, these prefatory statements make clear from the

outset that the novel's reformist social purpose is no incidental feature of its plot.

This study analyses the sequence of events, dialogue, characters' decisions and narrative outcomes. It distinguishes the author's intention from the work's actual achievement: to assume that a narrative invariably establishes precisely what its author wishes to say would not constitute criticism. Consequently, where idealistic resolutions simplify the complexity of social inequalities, they call for critical scrutiny.

The Central Problem: The Social Meaning of Widow Remarriage

The novel's question is not simply whether a person can marry again after the death of a spouse. Rather, it asks why society does not judge the widowhood of men and women by the same standards. In the case of a man, the family readily advances arguments in favour of a second marriage; in the case of a woman, the standards governing public shame, caste, prestige, children's futures and supposed propriety become far more severe. The novel makes these inequalities visible in the conversations of numerous characters and in social events.

Following the death of his first wife, Sunita, Ratan struggles with raising his children, managing his business and carrying the burden of memory. The suggestion of remarriage awakens hesitation within him. Sukanya's circumstances bring women's own experience into this discussion. Her intellectual gifts, her confrontation with humiliating accusations, her acceptance of assistance and her self-respecting conduct demonstrate why rebuilding a life should not depend upon a man's decision alone.

The work's social concerns are connected to Hindu marriage practices, rural panchayats, rumours, social standing and the safety of widows. The story repeatedly seeks to distinguish public opinion from moral truth: the opinion of the community is not its sole source, and opposition to a tradition is justified when that tradition injures human dignity.

Narrative Design: The Interconnections of Family, College, Town and Village

The story opens with Ratan's solitary reflections in a public garden. The colourful flowers and cheerful exterior of the garden are set against his personal emptiness. This contrast establishes the novel's emotional ground: life goes on outside, while the individual experiences an inward sense of incompleteness. Although the opening description of nature is not extensive, its function is more than decorative; it supplies a symbolic setting for Ratan's state of mind.

The male elders of Ratan's family, prominent figures in the panchayat, college students and teachers, bank employees and numerous village residents collectively constitute the novel's social world. The presence of so many institutions transforms a private question of marriage into a larger matter of public concern. Yet one consequence of this breadth is that some characters

never acquire biographical depth; they serve chiefly as representatives of ideological positions.

The novel develops two principal currents—the relationships between Ratan and Sukanya and between Rinki and Nirmal—alongside the episodes involving Kamlesh and the later characters. The advantage of this multiple-character arrangement is that it allows the social question to appear in various forms. Its limitation is that the sustained narrative presence of the title character's inner life is repeatedly diminished by other episodes.

A Sequential Reading: From the Opening to the Final Outcome

The main narrative explicitly bears the numbers 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9 and 10. Within the material occupying printed pages 45–64, a separate heading numbered '7' is not clearly marked. The following reading therefore identifies that intervening material as a 'seventh narrative phase', without claiming that the text contains an independently numbered chapter. This fact of textual division is significant to an examination of the novel's craft.

Part One: Ratan's Solitude and the Question of the Panchayat

The central scene of the first part is Ratan's solitary reflection. Three years after the death of his wife Sunita, he remains bound by memory. The practical demands of raising his children pull in one direction; fear of what society will say, and respect for his former relationship, pull in another. The author does not immediately install the possibility of remarriage in Ratan's mind. He first presents an unsettled person whose social and worldly circumstances have fallen out of balance.

Discussions involving Amirkantji's household and village society raise the issue of the panchayat's authority to pronounce decisions. What a respected member of the community says may amount to advice, but it cannot be the final judge of human freedom. The work's reformist temper emerges distinctly for the first time in this conflict.

> *'On what grounds have you delivered this panchayat decision?' (original printed page 3)*

This brief question contains the novel's ethical seed. The work does not oppose the very existence of the panchayat; it criticises intervention unsupported by a legitimate moral basis. Nevertheless, the psychological reasoning of the opposing side is not developed at length in the opening part, and the conflict begins to fall into a division between reformers and traditionalists.

Part Two: Tradition, Guardians and the Legitimacy of Remarriage

In the second part, discussion of Ratan's remarriage takes on a more explicitly social form. Arrangements for the family after Sunita's death, the future of the sons and the advice of elders are linked together. Marriage is presented not solely as a matter of love, but as a decision involving the family's many layers of responsibility.

The dialogue between religious destiny and human choice is engaging. Traditional beliefs concerning the influence of fate on birth, death and marriage are present in the story, yet the characters also make practical decisions. This dual outlook helps constitute the mentality of rural society: trust in the past alongside attempts to change the present.

Sukanya's personal introduction and the indications of her widowhood enter the narrative at this point. The social predicament of a woman is placed beside the male predicament that had already occupied the centre of the story. The structure thus prepares the ground for empathy and raises the question: if remarriage is considered possible for a man, why should the same possibility be denied to a woman?

Part Three: Sukanya's Voice and Self-Definition

In the third part, the direct introduction of Ratan and Sukanya through Ramdayalji is decisive. Ratan does not immediately reveal his name as a stranger; through conversation he creates an atmosphere of trust. Information about Sukanya's widowhood, her education and her child provides the episode's fundamental basis of sympathy.

Sukanya does not present herself merely as unfortunate or as an object of pity. Her intelligence, fearlessness in conversation and capacity to understand circumstances make her an active character. Hearing her experiences from the mouth of the woman who confronts society's harsh gaze is more effective than authorial instruction.

The limitation of this part is that Sukanya's entire life soon begins to be read in relation to her possible companionship with the male protagonist. A longer interval of independent existence between the question of self-sufficiency and that of marriage would have made the heroine's personality more substantial.

Part Four: College, Humiliation and the Ethics of Assistance

In the fourth part, events at college bring the social contradictions to a new level. The misconduct of Ranjan, an affluent and unruly student, the allegation against Sukanya, Kamlesh's intervention and a sequence of decisions by teachers and administrators demonstrate that a woman's dignity cannot be confined to the rules governing the household or marriage.

Kamlesh acts as a supportive friend. He opposes an unjust accusation and seeks to bring the facts to light. Here the educational institution itself becomes a site of conflict between justice and injustice. If a college's social prestige inclines it towards the powerful, a student's courage may be necessary to defend the truth.

> *'We are human beings, and it is our duty to protect humanity.' (original printed page 26)*

In this sentence, the basis of human morality is neither caste nor position nor physical attraction, but shared humanity. Yet the author's portrayal of the antagonistic student is relatively simple. A fuller development of the social

causes of economic privilege and a violent sense of entitlement would have deepened the work's realism.

Part Five: Companionship, the Proposal of Marriage and the Question of Consent

In the fifth part, Ratan and Sukanya's reunion, exchange of ideas and proposal of marriage move explicitly to the centre of the plot. Ratan understands the circumstances of his family, the passage of time and the possibility of social opposition. Sukanya is likewise conscious that a decision to remarry must rest not on sympathy alone, but on careful consideration of the realities of the future.

Between love and help, compassion and equality, shelter and independent choice, the novel poses a significant conflict. The question of remarriage is not the same for Sukanya as marriage might be for an unmarried young woman: her child, her past experience and her social image all bear upon the decision.

The author generally directs the characters towards the adoption of a clear ethical position. Consequently, the emotional intensity of the story is strong, though the complex economic and legal dimensions of the decision receive relatively little development. This is a structural tendency of the idealistic social novel.

The First Half of Part Six: Rinki and Nirmal, and Independent Choice

In the sixth part, the work approaches its central question from another perspective through Rinki and Nirmal's relationship. The working world of the bank, the advice of family elders, the children's future and proposals concerning marriage create a new setting. Advice initially associated with Ratan's life now becomes a means of making change possible in another household.

Rinki is a particularly important character. She appears as a working woman with self-respect who is attentive to her standing in society. In the episode concerning Nirmal's attraction, the question of choice extends beyond personal feeling to the family, prior marital commitments and social attitudes.

The achievement of this part is to present decisions about personal relationships as parallel experiences rather than the problem of one household alone. Its limitation is that the novel must leave the main Sukanya–Ratan narrative for a time in order to offer its wider social example.

Seventh Narrative Phase: From Social Constraint to Public Resistance

The intervening narrative expands through Rinki's moral uncertainty, Nirmal's family's agreement and Raghuwansh Babu's opposition to social convention. The story's debate becomes sharper as it shows how marriage, although a matter of personal desire, generates punitive pressure in the name of public respectability.

'Social constraints, nothing else.' (original printed page 54)

The force of this short exchange lies in its treatment of 'constraint' not as a law of human nature, but as a socially constructed, historically contingent institution. Public opinion is mobilised against private choice; accusations, financial penalties, threats from the panchayat and reformist arguments turn the conflict into a public one.

Raghuwansh Babu argues that social rules can claim legitimacy only when they protect human welfare. In this sense, the novel presents the possibility of collective action. Yet the outcome of public resistance changes comparatively quickly; there was scope for a fuller depiction of the prolonged difficulties that such change entails in numerous social institutions.

Part Eight: Ratan's Illness, the Transience of Life and Reconsidering the Family

In the eighth part, Ratan spends more time at home after retiring from service. His children have lives of their own, but he feels lonely within. His ill health brings home life's finitude. Medical advice, the family's preoccupations and a mind steeped in memory invest the question of love with fresh meaning.

An important change occurs here: remarriage is not merely a matter of youthful physical attraction. It also concerns insecurity as old age approaches, the absence of a companion and the need for emotional care. The author thus returns to the fundamental question of marriage at different stages of life.

Later episodes introduce the relationship between Suman and Vishal and the question of their families' approval. The similarity between the younger generation's love and the older generation's fear of shame and lost prestige allows the principal theme to recur. The comparison is useful, but the plot at times seems to accumulate too many illustrative incidents.

Part Nine: Sewakram, Class and the Economic Violence of Marriage

Through the life of Sewakram of Chandrapur, the ninth part takes the novel's social horizon beyond the personal question of marriage to class exploitation. Episodes concerning cultivators, labourers, wealthy families, interest, the devaluation of work and village power relations lend a new sharpness to its social criticism.

The experience of a character such as Sewakram shows that society's rules of propriety do not burden every class equally. Economically vulnerable people have limited choices, while influential people employ property and prestige to dictate conduct. At this level, Sukanya's discussion of widow remarriage acquires a social grounding in economic inequality.

The relationship between Suman and Vishal, and the opposition of their families, suggest that a new generation is seeking to establish emotional loyalties against social divisions. Nevertheless, outside intervention plays a substantial part in resolving the conflict; the characters' own capacity for organised political action could have received more attention.

Part Ten: Sukanya's Independent Action and Final Rehabilitation

The final part brings together Sukanya's journey, her acquaintance with the fellow railway passenger Chameli, acts of social assistance and events involving Sewakram's family. Sukanya is now portrayed not merely as a woman suffering from widowhood, but as a social worker capable of helping others through crises.

The episodes involving Chameli and social welfare work open up a new world of mutual assistance among the novel's women. Women's safety does not depend exclusively on male generosity; cooperation between women, public awareness and institutional intervention are also possible. This point is particularly important to the novel's feminist significance.

Eventually, in the case involving Sewakram, the intervention of influential people, action by the administration and a change in rural public opinion create the conditions for Ratan and Sukanya's remarriage. Ramdayalji's affection, familial acceptance and the formation of a new household out of two former families supply the story's resolution.

The final outcome offers heartfelt hope, although it develops the successful marriage of particular individuals more fully than it depicts a society-wide transformation of entrenched convention. Readers are left wondering how a widow without comparable assistance, or an economically powerless person, could secure the same rights. This unanswered question does not cancel the work's literary relevance; it broadens its critical meaning.

A Psychological and Social Examination of the Principal Characters

Sukanya: From an Object of Compassion to an Active Personality

The novel's title places Sukanya at its centre. Her life brings together the suffering of widowhood, the suspicion of society, the courage required to pursue education, the struggles of student life, the dependability of friendship, the responsibilities of motherhood and, later, engagement in social service. The heroine does not attain fulfilment merely as a woman eligible for marriage; she also gains the power to improve the lives of others.

Sukanya's independence does not develop at an even pace throughout the narrative. At times she resists through her own articulate voice; at other times she depends upon the moral assurances of Ratan, Kamlesh or other helpers. Such dependence may also reflect the realities of the society depicted. Nevertheless, the distance between that dependence and the novel's ideal of women's emancipation must be measured critically.

In the end, the title character is accepted in the identity of a ‘wife’. The question remains whether her work in society and the independent existence of her educated personality will be preserved after marriage. The novel does not explore this aspect of her future. Its silence constitutes a meaningful critical gap.

Ratan: Memory, Responsibility and the Desire for Companionship Again

Ratan's early widowerhood places him between grief and duty. For a man whose life has long been organised within the family, acknowledging his own solitude after meeting his sons' emotional needs is difficult. He honours the memory of his deceased wife, Sunita; the fear that a second marriage might seem to deny the past repeatedly holds him back.

Ratan possesses an idealism motivated by sympathy. Sukanya's education, talent and circumstances move him. Yet his willingness to listen to advice, his wish to avoid public disputes even when he disagrees with society, and his many deferred decisions prevent him from becoming an omnipotent protagonist. These human hesitations impart novelistic energy to his character.

Sunita: An Active Memory Despite Her Absence

The deceased wife Sunita is not physically present in the opening events, but her influence survives in Ratan's memories. She represents the emotional trust of the past. The possibility of Ratan's new relationship raises the question of fidelity to the old one. In this sense, an absent character remains active within the plot's moral structure.

Kamlesh, Ranjan and the Educational Establishment

Kamlesh is Sukanya's companion in adversity, a figure of resistance and a voice of young consciousness oriented towards justice. Ranjan's misbehaviour exposes the abuse of social privilege. The involvement of the college principal and teachers raises questions about the responsibilities of educational institutions. Kamlesh becomes an ideal of solidarity, while Ranjan suffers from a somewhat excessive simplification into a negative character.

Rinki and Nirmal: The Dilemmas of the Working Middle Class

Rinki's professional circumstances, her family and Nirmal's emotional insistence present an urban, middle-class social environment. Within it, a woman has employment, but family expectations and social standing continue to control marital decisions. The conflict between Rinki's individual aspirations and communal norms reveals the predicament of a new generation.

Raghuwansh Babu and the Village Panchayat

Raghuwansh Babu's role is to advance public arguments against entrenched convention. He seeks to establish that reform is possible from within society. His intervention against unjust directions from the panchayat brings out the importance of civic courage. The rapid attainment of collective agreement, however, is a mark of the novel's idealistic mode of resolution.

Sewakram, Vishal, Suman and Chameli

Through these later characters, the narrative moves beyond the private question of remarriage into the wider terrain of poverty, education, love, public respect and social cooperation. Sewakram is a figure experienced in class

exploitation; Vishal and Suman represent the emotional life of a new generation; and Chameli embodies the possibility of relationships and support among women. Their independent narrative development is limited, but together they extend the social canvas of this reformist novel.

A Perspective on Women, Widowhood and the Right to Choose Freely

The centre of Sukanya's engagement with women's questions is the moral and social right of a widow to enter married life again. In traditional society, widowhood has often been treated as a permanent negation of a woman's identity. Against this denial, the novel advances a claim for renewed life through women's education, social usefulness and love.

There are two levels to this perspective. The first is direct resistance to the shame imposed upon women and to prohibitions on remarriage. The second is an attempt to establish new relationships of human support within society. Sukanya's education, Kamlesh's friendship, Rinki's working life and Chameli's supportive role belong to this second level.

Yet if women's dignity is measured solely by success in securing remarriage, the legitimate lives of women who are unmarried, single or do not wish to marry will remain neglected. The novel itself does not examine all these alternatives in detail. It is therefore more consistent to regard it as a significant stage in the transition towards reform than as a complete philosophy of women's rights.

However important Ratan's ethical generosity may be, structural change remains incomplete if women's emancipation is reduced to ‘finding a generous man’. In this connection, the novel's later presentation of public organisation, opposition to the panchayat and administrative intervention is especially valuable.

Patriarchy, Public Opinion and Reformist Idealism

The novel repeatedly calls the language of public shame into question. The anxiety expressed in ‘What will people say?’ gives society an indirect power over personal decisions. Within rural systems of prestige, marriage is conventionally considered not simply a bond between two individuals but a matter of family honour, humiliation and caste position. The author invites readers to doubt the reasoning that is accepted as natural.

The work's reformist consciousness takes different forms in the conduct of Raghuwansh Babu, Kamlesh, Ramdayalji and Sukanya. These characters do not demand the total abolition of tradition; they seek to restore humane values within it. The work is thus not a revolutionary political manifesto but an ethical novel about transforming society from within.

The strength of this literary method is its capacity to draw readers into emotional participation. Social change is shown to be possible through individual generosity, public agreement and just conduct. Its limitation is that prolonged opposition from structures of power and social division sometimes disappears too quickly. Deeply entrenched inequalities do not invariably

change on the ground through a protagonist's speech or the intervention of a few well-wishers.

Narrative Craft: Multiple Strands, Coincidence and Resolution

The proliferation of episodes is a principal formal characteristic of Sukanya. Ratan's private memories, Sukanya's college life, the controversy over Rinki and Nirmal's marriage, public conflict in the village panchayat, Sewakram's experience of class oppression and the final scenes of social assistance are all linked by a single reformist axis. Thematic unity is strong, but the skill with which events are connected is not equally successful throughout.

Unexpected meetings between numerous characters and the timely arrival of social assistance increase the role of coincidence in the plot. Such coincidences serve the novel's philosophical objective—the triumph of human goodwill—but their excessive use reduces naturalness from the standpoint of psychological realism.

The narrator offers explicit value judgements on many occasions. Readers are told directly of the evils of social malpractice and the superiority of generous individuals. This technique approaches the manner of didactic prose. Yet several direct exchanges among Sukanya, Rinki and Ratan allow moral conflict to disclose itself through speech and action. These dialogue-driven passages are the livelier parts of the novel.

In the final chapter, numerous strands move towards resolution together. The consent of families, intervention by the police and administration, a change in public opinion and the success of remarriage give the story a positive conclusion. Nevertheless, greater intervals of time and more internal uncertainty between these developments would have made the outcome feel more thoroughly earned and credible.

Language, Dialogue and the Experience of Place

The author's Maithili prose rests upon the natural flow of conversation. Expressions such as ‘ki’, ‘kiek’, ‘ehan’, ‘ahan’, ‘babuji’ and ‘bajalah’ establish a sense of intimacy within the characters' social world. Beginning with the language of the household, the work moves into the institutional register of the college, the professional vocabulary of the bank and the communal speech of village meetings. This layered use of language conveys the breadth of the social setting.

The dialogue of different characters does not, however, always establish fully distinct linguistic personalities. In several places the voices of reformist characters become vehicles for the author's public opinions. Were differences in age, education, social class and geographical experience more audible in each character's language, their personalities would become more convincing.

Gardens, colleges, villages, towns, banks, railway journeys and family spaces associated with weddings construct several social worlds in the story. Description, however, principally serves the progress of the plot. The nature of Mithila, local sounds, subtle distinctions of dialect, details of agricultural life

and regionally specific metaphors receive comparatively little extended treatment. Thus, while the novel is firmly rooted thematically in Maithili society, it could have possessed greater richness of regional visualisation.

Sukanya in the History of the Maithili Novel: A Comparative Discussion

Comparison with Kanyadan: Women's Education and the Institution of Marriage

Harimohan Jha's Kanyadan (published in book form in 1933) is regarded as a notable text in the social criticism of the Maithili novel, particularly for its engagement with women's education, mismatched marriage and opposition to convention. It resembles Sukanya in questioning women's position within marriage. Yet the sharp humour and satire of Kanyadan differ from Sukanya's compassion-centred, resolution-oriented mode. One principally addresses a young girl's education before marriage and an unsuitable match; the other asks whether a woman can be granted a second chance at life after marriage. There is therefore thematic continuity without identity of technique.

Comparison with Paro: Women's Suffering and Social Structure

Paro (1946), by Baidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' (Nagarjun), offers a critical example of the tragedy of mismatched marriage and the social order imposed upon women. Paro brings out with particular severity the destructive consequences of controlling women's lives; Sukanya offers more optimistic scenes of possible change and humane assistance. The two works thus represent different narrative outcomes for women's experience. It would be inappropriate to claim precise similarities at the level of dialogue without a close reading of the original text of Paro; the comparison here rests only upon broad thematic resemblance.

Intertextual Contexts: The Author's Gudari Ke Lal and Swarna Kamal

In Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand''s other work, Gudari Ke Lal, the lives of disadvantaged people, social injustice and dignity are prominent concerns. In Sukanya, comparable ethical questions become debates about marriage, women's circumstances and social standing. Swarna Kamal is a distinct experiment in the genre of children's narrative, dealing with courage, guidance and moral victory. Once the clear generic differences among these three works are respected, one may recognise the recurrence of the author's interest in social justice. This comparative observation does not establish direct intertextual dependence between their characters or plots.

The Tradition of the Reformist Novel and Later Contexts

At different points in the development of the Maithili novel, writers have raised questions concerning social convention, women's education, marriage, caste, exploitation and changing communal life. Sukanya is distinctive in its representation of the coexistence of a twenty-first-century working middle class with local family customs. The bank office and the public panchayat appear within the same novel, creating a composite picture of old and new pressures upon women's choices.

The novel remains in contact with this historical tradition, but it does not supply a systematic answer to every contemporary feminist debate. Its tension between women's independence and society's acceptance of marriage makes it worthy of study.

The Work's Principal Literary Achievements

First, the novel's central achievement is its presentation of social inequality surrounding widow remarriage through both private and collective experience. Rather than relying on narrative instruction alone, it gives the issue several dimensions through Ratan and Sukanya's dilemmas, the disagreement involving Rinki and Nirmal, and pressure from the village panchayat.

Second, the importance of education and self-respect is shown through the heroine's struggles. Sukanya's college life and resistance to unjust accusations give her personality a human foundation independent of the proposal that she remarry.

Third, the ideal of human cooperation appears at several levels of the narrative. Teachers, fellow students, elders, families and administrators can act in the same ethical direction. The work therefore offers a social imagination grounded in hope.

Fourth, the parallel structures of the modern office and the traditional village disclose the double movement of contemporary change. Employment or education does not automatically eliminate harmful social practices; even some highly educated characters remain troubled by the pressure of public opinion.

Fifth, the heroine's capacity to help others in the closing episodes carries her beyond the restrictive image of a woman who simply endures suffering.

Critical Limitations and Unrealised Possibilities

The principal limitation is the relatively clear division between moral positions. Generous characters quickly put forward just arguments, while the conservative side often remains merely a representative of opposition. In actual society, self-interest, fear, economic compulsion and collective notions of honour are more contradictory and interdependent.

A second limitation is the plot's overexpansion. Numerous social examples intrude upon a sustained psychological exploration of Sukanya's inward transformation. They widen the novel's compass, but somewhat weaken continuity in the inner life of its title character.

Third is the speed of resolution. Problems attached to complex social institutions are often settled by a reasonable individual or an abrupt change in public opinion. Literary optimism matters, but a fuller depiction of the duration of conflict would have increased the story's social credibility.

Fourth is the danger of treating successful remarriage as the final sign of women's liberation. A more extended discussion of education, financial

security, property rights, marital consent and autonomy in decisions after marriage would have given the work greater depth in relation to contemporary feminism.

Fifth, from an editorial perspective, there is room to tighten recurring exchanges, lengthy statements of intention and the uniformly reformist speech of several characters. This observation does not imply removing the colloquial Maithili from the work; on the contrary, it implies preserving its local distinctiveness more effectively.

Sixth, an editorial inconsistency in numbering deserves attention: heading 8 follows heading 6 in the printed narrative. It would be useful to review this sectional division in a future edition. This is a matter of textual editing, not an inherent defect of the plot.

Conclusion: Beyond Sukanya's Remarriage

To read Sukanya only as a story of a happy marriage would narrow its wider meaning. The fundamental question is how much authority individuals possess over decisive choices in their own lives, and whether society becomes a friend or an obstacle to that authority. Ratan's widowerhood and Sukanya's experiences make this issue relevant to women and men alike, though the social risks fall more heavily on women. It is this inequality that the work brings into view.

The narrative draws its strength from faith in humanity, educational courage, personal compassion, public cooperation and the hope of forming a family anew. Its limitations lie in idealistic solutions, the simplification of antagonism and the many-stranded expansion of the plot. Even so, the novel makes the possibility of a dignified new life after widowhood a compelling moral concern within Maithili social fiction.

The critical conclusion is that Sukanya's achievement lies not only in remarrying Ratan but in gaining recognition as a woman who establishes her place in society anew through education, consent, experience and service. The question raised by her life does not end here. It goes on to ask how society can give every woman—whether she marries or does not marry—equal dignity and the opportunity to live freely. In this open question resides the novel's enduring relevance.

Chapter 7

Parivar (Family)

Memory, Disintegration and Reconstruction of the Joint Family

An Extended Literary Critique of Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand”s Parivar, with Separate Textual Analyses and a Comparative Discussion of the History of Maithili Children's Literature

In its publication details, Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand''s Parivar (2021) is described as a reminiscence-based novel. At its narrative centre is Narendra, a character who links the disintegration of the joint family, experiences of educational institutions, conflicts over inheritance and self-interest, social connections formed through music and theatre, questions of love marriage and the reconstruction of public life in the village. This essay principally argues that 'family' in the novel is not simply an institution of blood relationships, but an ethical community formed through care, participation, memory, economic judgement and social responsibility. Nevertheless, its idealistic solutions, the protagonist's ability to resolve almost every problem, the limited autonomy of women characters and its comparatively easy settlement of economic and political complexities all invite criticism. Alongside distinct analyses of the opening, middle and ending of the printed narrative, the genealogical material in the appendix is read as social memory. The Videha book and prose catalogues and Shishu Utsav archives are used to trace indicative developments in illustrated stories, children's novels and the digital dissemination of Maithili children's literature. Parivar itself, however, is not classified as a children's novel.

Introduction: The Semantic Range of the Title Parivar

The word 'family' signifies at once a physical arrangement for living together, relations of kinship, the sharing of labour, the collective management of property and a refuge of feeling. Writing about the joint family requires an author to hold all these levels together. Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand' gives this challenge narrative form through Narendra's life and several episodes of village experience. The story begins with a retired man's return to his village; thereafter, the family discipline, educational journey, hostilities and social service of his earlier life gradually come to light. In the end, the meaning of family no longer remains limited to descent alone.

It would not be enough for this study simply to praise the book as a direct transcription of a social ideal. The formal credibility, effect upon readers and ideological consequences of the novelist's proposed solutions must also be examined. Parivar's strongest feature is its resolve to connect intimate relationships to the village's public activities; its chief limitation is the tendency to resolve many causes of conflict through Narendra's individual judgement.

Bibliographical Description and Reminiscence-Based Form

The primary text is the first edition of Parivar (2021). Its publisher is named as Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Uparadaha, Darbhanga district; the printer is given as Printwell, Tower, Darbhanga; and the contribution price is stated as 100 rupees. The subtitle 'reminiscence-based novel' appears clearly both on the cover and on the internal title page. Read alongside this generic designation, the author's 'Two Words' and Murlidhar Jha's 'Introduction' reveal two different levels of the work's declared purpose: the author claims a

basis in actual experience, while the introduction emphasises the novel's social ideals and the conduct of its characters.

Three levels of evidence have been retained: first, the narrative content and text of the printed book itself; second, its prefatory material, authorial statement and closing genealogy; third, the book listings and children's literature archives available on Videha. Page numbers accompanying quotations refer to the original printed edition. Quotation marks have been reserved for passages whose precise wording can be established; the remaining discussion is presented as an account and interpretation of the text. References to other works recorded in Videha's listings are chiefly confined to genre, title and archival presence; indirect access has not been presented as though it were direct reading.

The Introduction and 'Two Words': The Novel's Account of Itself

The 'Introduction' written by Murlidhar Jha presents the novel as an example of Narendra's struggle through life. It emphasises the progression from childhood deprivation and education to his relationship with Guruji, experiences of love, village celebrations and activities for the common good. The introduction signals early on that Narendra is not merely a narrator of suffering he has endured but a character who actively tries to change his circumstances. It is necessary to distinguish this appreciative assessment in the prefatory matter from the novel's independent artistic achievements; the introduction cannot stand in for a critical conclusion.

The generic claim made in the author's 'Two Words' is particularly significant. He connects the story's material with lived experience, while also indicating that the names of characters and places have been changed. The distinction lies at the boundary between memoir and fiction.

> *'The book Parivar is a reminiscence-based novel founded upon entirely true events.' (printed page 7)*

The coexistence of a claim to 'entirely true events' with the attribution of 'fictional' names constitutes a genuine tension in the work's narrative poetics. The book asks readers to trust it as they might trust a document, although its selection of events, conversations and coincidences falls within the creative liberty of a novel. A reasonable critical position is to regard the claim to truth as the author's own declaration, not to consider every event independently verified history. Nor should the author's caution in this matter be turned into an accusation of mystery-making or falsehood.

'Two Words' emphasises Narendra's affection, the ideal of the joint family, the social usefulness of overcoming mutual opposition and the enthusiasm of the younger generation. In this light, it would be incomplete to regard the novel simply as a sorrowful family story; it is also an imaginative proposal for voluntary forms of social conduct.

A Separate Reading: Entering the Story and Returning to the Village

The original narrative begins with Narendra's arrival in his village after retirement. Re-entering village relationships after a modern professional life supplies the frame of the story. Narendra's welcome, his earlier acquaintances among the people and indications of familial conflict carry the narrative backwards from the present moment into remembered time. Readers learn at once that the protagonist is being judged not merely by his lineage or financial position, but also by his usefulness to public life.

> *'Today Narendra has returned to the village after retirement.' (printed page 9)*

This simple opening produces a rich narrative effect. 'Today' establishes an immediate present; 'retirement' suggests a long period that has passed; 'village' becomes the enduring site of memory. In these three units of expression, the story establishes the foundation of its temporal structure. Instead of a chronological life history, the narrator first introduces an adult Narendra enriched by experience. The struggles of the past can then be compared with his recognition and contributions in the present.

In the opening part, self-interest, competition for property and Narendra's comparatively conciliatory outlook come face to face. If this opposition becomes a simple division between 'good' and 'bad' people, the characters lose complexity. Nevertheless, the early identification of the village's contradictions establishes the novel's ethical axis.

A Separate Reading: Childhood, Education and the Politics of Dependence

Accounts of Narendra's early life attach particular importance to economic deprivation, family protectors and educational opportunity. Episodes involving Nilambar Babu and Shwetambar Babu suggest the unequal distribution of authority, discipline and protection within the home. The perspective of childhood is moving in itself: a child does not actively create family property disputes, yet may be the first to bear their consequences.

Narendra's commitment to education represents the novel's optimistic outlook. Learning is not presented merely as a means of passing examinations, but as a route towards the formation of personality and an equal place in society. Here one must distinguish childhood remembered from the nature of children's literature: the story depicts childhood, but its lengthy intellectual conversations, network of relationships and retrospective interpretation of an entire life chiefly address adult readers.

There is also another possible reading of the journey out of deprivation. Life stories of successful individuals often transform inequalities embedded in social structures into narratives of personal talent and effort. Narendra's achievement deserves praise, but the question remains: how many children in that village do not receive comparable shelter, guidance or opportunity? The novel's wider ethical significance becomes clearer in the light of such unanswered social questions.

A Separate Reading: Relations among Brothers and the Crisis of the Joint Family

In the middle of the narrative, questions of property, income and expenditure, the authority to make decisions and mutual trust emerge within the joint family. Family unity is not simply an emotional sentiment but a matter of practical organisation. Who will head the family? Who is responsible to whom? How will labour or resources be shared, and which rules will govern disputes? The direct or indirect presence of these questions increases the social vitality of the novel.

Narendra's emphasis on collective welfare rather than private gain is central to the work's inspiration. The novelist locates the root of conflict in conduct that places immediate individual interests above the family's long-term interests. Yet criticism must ask whether real inequalities of property, the invisible labour of care, women's inheritance and differences in generational expectations can all be explained simply as selfishness. The novel's solution-oriented outlook repeatedly simplifies these complexities.

An effective aspect of the narrative design is that family disagreements have consequences for village life. Bitterness within the household, the fragmentation of groups and the decline of shared community resources appear interconnected. In this sense, the novel crosses the boundary between the domestic narrative and the social narrative.

A Separate Reading: From Dispute to Cooperation Through Culture

Narendra and those associated with him attempt to reduce divisions through cultural activity. Theatre, music and collective events carry the narrative out of the inner rooms of the house and into public space. Even people from opposing factions come together on a single stage to rehearse a play; the labour of cultural production provides opportunities for conversation.

The dramatic performance assumes creative significance here because theatre visibly allows social ‘roles’ to change. When a person speaks in the voice of another character and encounters an audience's response, he or she may move beyond narrow self-interest. The work affirms this possibility. Yet opposition does not necessarily disappear immediately after a performance. Where the narrative reaches agreement too quickly, some of the hardness of reality is lost.

> *‘Whatever we all wish to do, for whom is it intended? For this very society, is it not?’ (printed page 16)*

The novel's social purpose is expressed concisely in this exchange. ‘We all’ invokes collective agency, ‘for whom’ raises the question of responsibility, and ‘society’ opens up wider human relations beyond the family. The sentence also offers an ethical self-definition of Narendra's character.

A Separate Reading: Shankar, Deepali and a New Basis for Relationships

The episodes involving Shankar and Deepali, associated with Guruji's family, present a conversation between the feelings of a younger generation and social control. Musical training, mutual attraction, the possibility of marriage and the search for appropriate social acceptance link this subplot to the principal discussion of family. Love is not merely private excitement here: it appears alongside adult decision-making, the proprieties of the teacher–student relationship, parental anxieties and institutional prestige.

Shankar's musical education and Deepali's practice of dance are also susceptible to a symbolic reading. Just as Narendra's early educational journey becomes a means of opportunity, artistic training gives the younger generation room to imagine a future beyond conventional understandings of livelihood. At this point, the novel seeks a compromise between the family's protective outlook and the autonomous aspirations of the young.

The narrator does not regard love marriage as either utterly impossible or inherently improper, but legitimacy is gained chiefly through mediation by elders. This offers one model for reconciling tradition and modernity. The question remains how much direct authority Shankar and Deepali possess over decisions concerning their own futures. Familial consent brings happiness in the narrative, but it would be premature to take it as complete evidence of equal agency for women and men.

A Separate Reading: The Educational Profession, Employment and Social Mobility

Episodes concerning Shankar's university-level study of music include conversations about examinations, employment, appointment and professional qualifications. Against the tendency to regard music as entertainment alone, this part demonstrates its institutional importance. The contrast between Guruji's anxieties and Narendra's enthusiasm reveals different life experiences. Art, teaching and marriage become parts of a single project of life.

> *'Sir, I cannot give such a guarantee. Nevertheless, I will certainly make the effort.' (printed page 57)*

The importance of this reply lies in the protagonist's acknowledgement of his limits. Elsewhere in the work, Narendra's decisions often appear to succeed almost miraculously. Here, his reluctance to offer a 'guarantee' gives the character a genuine moral modesty. Such moments draw him somewhat away from the conventional image of an all-powerful reformer.

A Separate Reading: Nava Ramayan, Public Memory and Village Institutions

In the later part of the novel, attempts at cultural renewal within the village assume a more tangible form. References to a Vidyapati memorial celebration, collective programmes, public discussion and projects such as Nava Ramayan express a wish to organise the village's social energies. Formally, the narrative

takes an interesting turn here: the man who resolves household quarrels emerges as the coordinator of communal programmes.

The novel does not reduce cultural programmes to religious ritual alone; they also involve questions of organising committees, expenditure, public relations, cooperation, performance spaces and public endorsement. The story consequently creates a small sociology of cultural management. It is particularly significant that these programmes provoke both enthusiasm and opposition: unanimity does not come automatically in public life.

A critical question raised by these episodes concerns when institutional rules may be changed in the name of public welfare and when accepted procedures should be followed. Narendra's conduct ought to be judged not solely by its outcome but also by the transparency of its procedures. The book provides enough narrative material to raise such questions, even if its ultimate tone remains conciliatory.

A Separate Reading: The Epilogue and the Expansion of 'Family'

The final section brings together Narendra's later life, the lives of his children, the separate households of brothers and sisters, and their continuing social connections. The story establishes a kind of circular relationship between the loss of the joint family at the beginning and the broader emotional connections at the end. Family no longer entails an obligation to live under one roof; mutual support, communication and happiness remain possible even when people live far apart.

> *'Then Narendra felt that his family really seemed like a "family".' (printed page 76)*

The novel's final judgement may be read as a reinterpretation of its title. The first 'family' is the complex group of actual biographical relationships; the second 'family' becomes the name for a desired moral quality—affection, respect, communication and reciprocity. This repetition of the word encapsulates the entire journey of meaning undertaken by the book. Nevertheless, the sentence tells readers its conclusion more than it allows room for an open question. Both its effective brevity and its didactic certainty deserve attention.

Narrative Structure: Memory, the Present and Retrospection

Parivar proceeds not as a linear historical chronicle but as a reminiscence-based novel. Narendra's return to the village as a retiree supplies the initial basis; memories of past hardships, protective figures, education, domestic disagreements, artistic relationships and social reputation are subsequently reassembled across several temporal layers. This design corresponds to the usual movement of memory, in which remembering particular individuals can accelerate a sequence of events.

Nevertheless, a narrative structured through memory presents a difficulty. Many episodes contain entire conversations reconstructed in full, which would be hard to regard as verbatim recollections from decades later. This is not a

defect peculiar to the novel, but a generic limitation: the distance between the truth of reminiscence and artistic reconstruction demands care. The author's acknowledgement that characters and places have been altered already marks this mixed form.

Narendra's character gives ethical continuity to the group of incidents, while his mature presence connects the different episodes. The advantage of this structure is the stability of its narrative centre; its disadvantage is that the independent complexities of other characters are frequently relegated to the background.

Characterisation: Narendra's Idealism and Its Limits

Narendra's personality is shaped by education, self-discipline, cultural interests, benevolence and attempts to preserve relationships. His preference for collective well-being over private advantage within family life defines his moral identity. The novel makes him an 'ideal' figure, but the value of such a figure depends upon the complexity of his engagement with characters who oppose him. The more readily the causes of conflict are labelled 'selfishness', the fewer opportunities readers have to hear the other side's economic or emotional arguments.

Nilambar Babu, Shwetambar Babu, Guruji, Shankar, Deepali, Suman and the other characters are not merely decorations in the protagonist's biography; each represents a different dimension of family, education, inheritance or social reputation. Yet representation is not identical with personality. At times the novelist makes a character the vehicle for an issue, and psychological subtlety then becomes relatively slight. Opposing voices such as Suman's sustain conflict, but the full circumstances behind their reasoning receive less attention than Narendra's idealism.

Language, Dialogue and Style

The book's principal language is accessible, dialogue-driven Maithili. Village speech, respectful forms of address, the vocabulary of kinship and contemporary terms associated with public programmes coexist within the narration. The combination presents the linguistic character of modern village life. Fields of vocabulary relating to schools, departments, examinations, music, offices and committees prevent the book from becoming a one-dimensional picture of folklore.

Conversation makes the characters' disagreements direct and visible. The recurrence of questions and answers is part of Narendra's rational mode: he explains matters to others, listens to objections and guides discussion towards an ethical conclusion. Some conversations create a theatrical pace, particularly those concerning Guruji and Shankar's relationship and deliberations over village programmes. Yet the repeated use of long argumentative speeches turns narrative scenes into something resembling essays. This formal imbalance can be understood in relation to the novel's educational intention.

The work trusts in the power of 'telling'; silence, suggestion, brief scenes and independent descriptions of objects play relatively small roles. Readers are usually shown clearly how to make a value judgement. This makes the subject accessible, but somewhat restricts its potential for multiple literary meanings.

Women Characters, the Family and Gender

Family memories are organised predominantly through fathers, uncles, brothers, Guruji and social leadership. Women characters appear in roles related to affection, inherited values, love, marital decisions and domestic continuity. Deepali's dedication to dance demonstrates women's creative ability; she is not merely a potential bride but a person active in the arts. Nevertheless, the independent conditions of her decisions, obstacles to professional achievement and plans for the future might have been explored more fully.

Within the joint family, preparing food, providing care, tending the elderly, raising children and performing household work are frequently distributed unequally. When the novel presents the extended household as an ideal, it becomes necessary to ask whose shoulders bear the burden of this 'shared' work. Women's property rights, education and marital autonomy can be approached through the indications present in the narrative rather than through explicit statements of principle. In this respect, Parivar provides suitable material for new criticism: the worth of its familial ideal must also be assessed through the visible participation of women.

Class, Property and Rural Modernity

Discussions of Narendra's economic hardship, his later employment, his brothers' educational achievements and conflicts over family property register changing patterns of social mobility in rural society. The prospect of education and positions in government or professional life suggests a change in older agrarian measures of status. Modernity here does not simply mean leaving the village; it is a project of reinvesting experience gained in modern institutions back into village life.

The contradiction in this project is that the successful protagonist's character and personal connections become so decisive that questions of collective institutional reform may disappear behind his goodwill. A more extended examination of the resource gap between prosperous and disadvantaged families, local power structures, inheritance rules and unequal opportunities could have made the narrative more realistic. This shortcoming is a limit of the work's social idealism, not a denial of the author's good intentions.

The Appendix Genealogy: Text, Document and Historical Caution

After the principal narrative, printed pages 77–86 contain genealogical diagrams of several lineages associated with the village of Uparadaha. This material is not an ordinary epilogue. Through lines of descent, it offers a visual arrangement of individuals, families, memories of relationships and successive

generations. The appendix gives the novel's title, Parivar, the perspective of extended social time: where the story asks about ethical coexistence, the genealogy presents the structural memory of blood relationships.

The narrative and the appendix, however, do not operate at the same epistemological level. The novel combines changed names and constructed events; the genealogy may claim to give historical information about an actual community. Before using it as such, names, generations, branches and dates would require separate verification against local documents and living oral traditions. This essay reads the genealogy as literary and cultural evidence of remembered kinship, not as a completely verified history of descent.

Another important distinction is that genealogies may principally record names along male lines of descent; marriage into families, women's labour, affectionate bonds, adoption and other forms of care may remain obscure in their diagrams. This omission makes the novel's ethical conception broader still: a living family is more than a bloodline; it is also the practice of care and mutual responsibility.

A Comparative Discussion of the History of Maithili Children's Literature

Parivar does not itself belong to the category of children's literature. Videha's prose and book catalogues identify it as a reminiscence-based novel, whereas the author's Swarna Kamal is explicitly recorded as a 'children's novel', including in the Shishu Utsav list. The author's prose thus contains distinct generic categories for an adult-oriented work of reminiscence and a narrative addressed to children. To discuss Parivar in the history of children's literature without making this distinction clear would be a generic error.

Videha's children's literature records document several forms for young Maithili readers: children's songs and verse, stories, drama, illustrated fiction, picture sequences, translations, popular discussions of science and children's novels. Preeti Thakur's Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Picture Stories (listed for 2008), Maithili Picture Stories (2009), Folk Deities of Mithila (2010) and Vidyapati's Purush Pariksha (2012) form an archival sequence of adaptations of narrative and cultural heritage for children. Works such as Gajendra Thakur's Bal Mandali/Kishor Jagat (2009) and Taraharime Parilok (2022) illustrate the separate recognition given to child and adolescent audiences.

Videha's listing also records titles across genres, such as Chonha by Jagadanand Jha 'Manu'; Taregan and Nai Dharaiye by Jagdish Prasad Mandal; Bilai Mausi by Nita Jha; Hamar Gaam by Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi'; Teen Ta Bal Natak by Munnaji; Koili Ghuri Aau by Sujit Kumar Jha; and Swarna Kamal by Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'. Only the stated genres and titles in the catalogue are being compared here. No unverified judgements are offered about the plots or techniques of these works.

The historical conclusion permitted by this limited evidence is that the available digital archives indicate the development of varied genres and authorial approaches in children's literature; they cannot substitute for a comprehensive history of the period. Dates of publication are likewise the

information given in Videha's archival entries, not the result of independently verifying every edition of each original book.

Children as Readers and Parivar: Connections and Differences

Parivar includes children's experiences, education, parental conduct and the atmosphere of the joint family, all of which may interest scholars of childhood. Yet the work also contains extended social arguments, adult conflicts over property, employment, marriage arrangements, institutional decisions and a life history stretching into retirement. Given the breadth of its narrative strands, the philosophical quality of its conversations and its reconstruction of memory, it does not appear to have been designed expressly for children.

Its potential points of comparison with a children's novel such as Swarna Kamal might be ‘ethical education’ or ‘a developing character’; these broad similarities, however, do not establish generic identity. Criticism of children's literature should consider the intended audience, sentence rhythms, conflicts appropriate to different age groups, the perspectives of child characters, illustration and narrative autonomy. Parivar's value lies in showing how childhood is reconstructed in adult memory. Its historical place is beside children's literature as a work of social remembrance, rather than within the central current of the children's novel itself.

The Method of Literary History: Distinguishing Catalogue, Text and Evaluation

Videha's book, prose and Shishu Utsav pages are important for making modern Maithili literature accessible. The ability to view different titles and genres in a common archival setting allows readers to map contemporary tendencies. Yet inclusion in a catalogue does not prove a work's artistic superiority, and exclusion from a list does not erase its historical importance. For literary history, the catalogue is an initial guide; the decisive grounds of criticism must be the original text, edition details and evidence of contemporary reception.

Parivar usefully illustrates this method. Videha's prose catalogue makes clear that works by the same writer occupy different genres: Gaam-Ghar as a story collection, Sujata, Gudari Ke Lal and Sukanya as novels, Swarna Kamal as a children's novel, and Parivar as a reminiscence-based novel. Independent examination of these texts would be necessary to reach a final judgement about the author's overall development as a prose writer. The published diversity of genres nevertheless indicates the breadth of his interests.

Literary Achievements Without Which the Picture Would Be Incomplete

The novel's first achievement is the creative enlargement of its title. The author carries a story that begins with Narendra's immediate family into village public life, education, artistic practice and social responsibility. Its second achievement is the attempt to transform remembered experience into a novelistic narrative: temporal distance allows the protagonist's decisions to

be evaluated. The third achievement is an outlook that regards the positive possibilities of rural modernity—education, employment, the arts and public cooperation—not as mutually exclusive but as complementary.

A fourth achievement is the ease of conversation in the local language. Mithila's forms of family address, styles of mutual disagreement and negotiations over reconciliation create a dense human atmosphere. A fifth achievement is the provision of a visual dimension to long-term kinship through the genealogy at the end. With due acknowledgement of its limitations, the appendix supplies useful material for the novel's social study.

The Work's Limitations: A Critical Reconsideration

The principal formal limitation is Narendra's nearly unvarying moral superiority. Such characters inspire readers but make it difficult to do full justice to opposing positions. A second limitation is the recurrence of explanatory narration: rather than allowing values to emerge naturally from the characters' experience, the author explicitly proclaims his conclusions. A third limitation is the excessive importance assigned to individual solutions to social problems; the finer questions of property, labour, legal rights and institutional transparency do not receive sustained equal attention.

Fourth is the uneven depth of the gender perspective. Although women characters are emotionally present, they do not everywhere gain an entirely independent space for decisions. Fifth is the possibility that success across many sequences of events appears too easily achieved. Such criticism does not disparage the social purpose of the work; rather, it asks how so ambitious an ideal might be transformed into more credible artistic form.

Conclusion: From Blood Relations to Social Reciprocity

Parivar's principal literary contribution is that it does not confine grief over the disintegration of the joint family to lamentation. Narendra's story searches for possible new connections among generations and social institutions. The value of family exceeds lineage or residence under one roof. It is tested by opportunities for education, respect for elders, the talents of young people, collective engagement with folk culture and the ethical ability to consider everyone's welfare. The final ‘family’ of the novel denotes bonds that can survive through mutual affection and cooperation even after households and occupations have become separate.

At the same time, the limitations of the work's idealism need to remain clear. The notion that all disputes in society can be resolved by benevolent mediation is not always sufficient; genuine social justice demands concrete attention to structural inequality, women's agency, property rules and institutional accountability. Because of this tension, Parivar becomes more than an agreeable lesson about social conduct: it is a literary document inviting criticism of the changing meaning of family in modern Maithili society. Its relationship to the history of children's literature extends to shared

elements such as remembered childhood and ethical instruction, but generically it stands apart as a reminiscence-based novel.

Appendix: Comparative Map

This table summarises only the generic information available in the archives; no comparisons of plots have been invented where the original works do not substantiate them.

Work / Author	Genre Listed by Videha	Valid Basis of Comparison with Parivar
Parivar — Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'	Reminiscence-based novel	Direct narrative and conceptual analysis of the original text
Swarna Kamal — Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'	Children's novel	A different intended readership and generic designation within the same author's work
Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Picture Stories — Preeti Thakur	Illustrated stories for children	Archival distinction in illustration and modes of reading for children
Chonha — Jagadanand Jha 'Manu'	Children's novel	The documented presence of the children's novel as a genre
Taregan — Jagdish Prasad Mandal	Collection of short inspirational stories for children	Generic distinction between brief inspirational fiction and an extended reminiscence-based narrative
Hamar Gaam — Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi'	Children's novel	Different readership category despite a similarity in titles referring to the village
Bilai Mausi — Nita Jha	Collection of short stories for children	Difference of scale and genre between children's short fiction and an adult novel
Natasha — Devanshu Vats	Children's picture sequence	Distinction in digital/illustrated presentation of visual stories

Part Three

Word-Portraits, Power and Mythological Reconsideration

Delhi Ke Park · Yachak Ke Nahi · Maharani Kaikeyi

Chapter 8

Delhi Ke Park (A Park in Delhi)

The Village–City Conflict, Civic Dialogue and the Art of the Literary Sketch

Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’s Delhi Ke Park is not merely a description of a particular city park. It is a multilayered, dialogic literary sketch of migration, retirement, memories of the village, urban sociability and changing civic relationships. For the author, a bench in a Delhi park becomes a public forum where people from different regions, languages, professions and generations compare their experiences. Spanning nine sections, the work constructs its image of society less through the excitement of a plot than through questions and answers, the development of episodes and exchanges of arguments. This study critically examines its genre, narrative perspective, configuration of characters, village–city discourse, language, migrant consciousness, class perspective and civic ethics. On the basis of Videha’s bibliography of Maithili children’s literature, it also clarifies the work’s generic distinction: Delhi Ke Park is not a children’s book, although its intergenerational experiences and instructive conversations may make it a comparative text in the study of literature for children and adolescents.

The Work, Its Genre and Structural Features

The title page and publication details of Delhi Ke Park describe it as a shabdachitra, or literary sketch; its English description calls it a “Maithili Literary Sketch.” The first edition appeared in 2018, published by Gosaauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Uparadaha, Darbhanga. Nine numbered sections occupy printed pages 11–82 of the work. The discussion of personal names, the sequence of sections and individual episodes is tied to the publication and printed material available to the reader. What is offered here is a paraphrastic account of the text’s import, not a quotation of its original sentences.

It is important at the outset to recognise that this book is not a children’s novel. Videha’s book catalogue likewise classifies Delhi Ke Park as a literary sketch while identifying Swarna Kamal, by the same author, separately as a children’s novel. Comparison with the history of children’s literature is useful here not to alter the work’s primary genre but to understand changing readerships, the transmission of language between generations and the place of family within narrative.

The Literary Sketch as a Genre: Social Configuration Rather Than Event

In a literary sketch, a character’s speech, social conduct, the influence of the setting and the organisation of thought take precedence over a single decisive event or the necessary sequence of a novelistic plot. Delhi Ke Park is a clear example of this method. The park is a meeting place for numerous adults, particularly people spending time there after retirement. One day’s conversation generates fresh questions the next; new visitors introduce their experiences of life, while familiar speakers raise further questions. From this recurrence emerges a broad portrait of society.

In the title, "Delhi" signifies the modern metropolis and the "park" a place of public repose. Yet repose is not passive in this work: it entails the labour of discussion, dispute, criticism, empathy, disagreement and self-examination. Although the village is geographically distant from the park, it remains continuously present in the characters' thoughts. They return repeatedly to food, housing, pensions, their children's employment, cultivation, linguistic insecurity, education, politics, social service and old age. The work consequently turns not a tourist attraction but the living memory of rural life within metropolitan existence into its stage.

This form carries both achievements and limitations. The author can accommodate diverse ideas within brief episodes; but when characters begin delivering extended analyses without interruption, their distinctive voices are sometimes submerged beneath the author's ideas. The conjunction of the literary sketch's quality of "what is seen" and the essay's quality of "what is explained" is at once the work's distinguishing feature and its central critical tension.

Narrative Architecture: The Gradual Expansion of Nine Sections

Across its nine sections, the narrative develops through the enlargement of its themes rather than through a linear succession of dramatic reversals. The comparison of village and city that underlies the initial encounter gradually extends to linguistic identity, retired life, aspirations for housing, employment, the disintegration of families, public trust, social responsibility and political memory. A loose but recognisable intellectual unity binds this progression: how does someone who has left the village for the city redefine obligations and the sense of belonging? The park is the laboratory for this question.

Individual Readings of the Nine Sections

Section One: Shyam Babu, Vivek and the Imagined Return to the Village

At the beginning, Shyam Babu is a retired man living in Delhi with his son Vivek. His way of life after retirement, his desire to visit the village, the conveniences of the city and memories of rural life all arise within a single domestic episode. The scene that begins with the park in Delhi gradually becomes a question: is one's connection with the native village a bond of affection, a practical relationship or merely a memory? The author does not present the village as an uncomplicated ideal; he also raises practical questions concerning meals, social distance and altered circumstances.

An episode involving a dog is particularly significant. Comparing relations between human beings and animals raises questions of companionship, ownership, entitlement and trust. The force of the episode lies in the way an animal's loyalty acts as a moral mirror when self-serving human relationships come under criticism. Yet, if the animal–human comparison is generalised too far, the complexity of human social relations risks being reduced to a

simple moral binary. The first section may therefore be regarded as the conceptual seed of the entire work.

Section Two: Khushwant Singh's Punjabi Experience and Linguistic Coexistence

With Khushwant Singh's entry in the second section, the park becomes a multilingual meeting ground. The perspective of a retired Punjabi speaker runs alongside that of the Maithili-speaking narrator. Questions arise about attachment to one's mother tongue, coexistence with other languages, Delhi's population drawn from many regions and linguistic identity. Through a single character, the author begins to delineate multilingual Delhi: the city is not the possession of one linguistic community but the shared outcome of numerous migrations.

This section matters to Maithili readers because affection for one's language and respect for another need not be opposed to one another. At certain turns in the conversation, however, general statements are made about cultural or regional character. Such remarks should be understood as a character's personal experience, not as established social-scientific facts. With that qualification in mind, the section's multilingualism emerges as an achievement.

Section Three: Ajay Babu's Administrative Experience and the Village after Retirement

The introduction of Ajay Babu, who has been associated with the Indian Administrative Service, brings out the distinction between professional standing and attachment to the village. Members of his family have established themselves in the city, but memories of the ancestral village remain alive. Where should a home be built after retirement, how can one continue to be of social use, and in what form should one fulfil responsibilities towards the ancestral place? These questions make the section predominantly reflective.

Returning to the village is not treated here simply as an emotional proposition; it entails obligations, resources, family expectations and practical difficulties. The author's encouraging voice favours the village, yet a suitable critical assessment must observe that retired people do not share the same finances, health, connection with land or family circumstances. The more the dialogue acknowledges the multiplicity of individual choices, the more persuasive its social appeal becomes.

Section Four: Khanna Sahib's Experiences of the Body, Language and Dependence

Khanna Sahib attracts the reader's attention through his active presence in the park. Walking, physical exercise, humour, a Punjabi-speaking environment and relations with his family offer a different picture of urban leisure. The section does not depict only the inactivity of old age; it also portrays the desire to retain control over one's body and time after the end of professional service.

References to Khanna Sahib's son's education, higher studies and professional mobility carry the account beyond the confines of the home into metropolitan competition. Education here is a means of advancement, but the position of the elderly within the household may become precarious. Such contradictions prevent the character from remaining merely a humorous figure; he becomes a bearer of social change. One limitation is that lengthy statements sometimes turn him into a spokesman for ideas; nevertheless, his presence introduces ease and variation into the book's tone.

Section Five: Sudhakarji, Teaching, Scarcity and Social Inequality

Sudhakarji's story brings the narrative onto the difficult terrain of salaries, financial struggle, teaching, children's education and family responsibilities. The discussion of educating several children, hoping to acquire a home and managing with limited means poses a necessary question about the story of urban development: everyone may value education, but not everyone possesses the same financial capacity to obtain education of good quality. The interdependence of a teacher's labour and the family's future becomes evident.

Discussion of land, housing, loans or savings can be read as evidence of a lower-middle-class aspiration for security. Here the work depicts not the glamour of consumption but the arithmetic of subsistence. Some episodes become didactic, but Sudhakarji's experience introduces immediate everyday hardship rather than political slogans. The park ceases to be merely a leisure space and becomes a comparative classroom of unequal living conditions.

Section Six: Ramanji's Generational Perspective, Residence and Local Responsibility

Ramanji arrives at the park bearing the experience of an educated life shaped by employment. His children's education, the possibility of work abroad or in another city, the fear of family fragmentation and security in old age all shape this section. Life in the city may seem comfortable, yet the geographical dispersal of a family does not extinguish questions of intimacy. The narrator contrasts memories of rural society's collective life with urban anonymity.

In the latter part of the section, possibilities of change in the village, local service and social responsibility gather force. The central question is important: how might knowledge, capital and professional skills acquired while living away from the village be put to use for society once more? This public-spirited appeal is the ethical backbone of the work. Yet, because its account offers insufficiently concrete details about inequalities of caste, economics and gender within the village, the proposals for rural improvement remain somewhat broad and abstract.

Section Seven: An Unknown Visitor, Medical Service and the Crisis of Trust

In this section an encounter with a new visitor to the park opens into questions of social mistrust, the need for personal introductions and the ethics of service. Alongside the visitor's connection with Dr Kiran, the discussion turns to village life, the treatment of patients, professional service and the

structure of the family. Particularly prominent is the difficulty of initiating social relationships in a metropolis: trusting an unfamiliar person is no longer easy.

The account of medical service and returning to the village points to a concrete possibility of civic responsibility. Personal goodwill, however, cannot by itself establish a complete system of community healthcare. Institutions, infrastructure, trained colleagues and local participation are necessary. Read with this distinction in mind, the section moves beyond simplistic praise of social service towards practical questions of public policy.

Section Eight: Budhna, Marukh Kaka and the Changing Moral Meaning of Rural Life

Against the evening setting of the park, the conversation involving Budhna and Marukh Kaka expands the picture of a changing village. Land, labour, cultivation, family decisions, debt, aspirations for employment and the compulsion to leave the village enter the same episode. Budhna is not merely an ideal representative of the wish to remain in the village; his remarks contain economic instability, social experience and a complicated attachment to his native place.

The section is especially important for its fundamental question: "A village for whom?" Is a village only an ancestral home, or is it a practical network of livelihood, social justice, personal dignity and collective cooperation? The true test of the hopeful rural future envisaged by the narrator is the actual life of working people. The eighth section therefore challenges a romantic portrayal of rural life. Its irony is that some discussions move away from economic determinants and turn into moral instruction, where fuller dramatic presentation would have been preferable.

Section Nine: Raghuvansh Babu, Public Work and Political Memory

The ninth section is the longest. With the arrival of Raghuvansh Babu, conversations in the park extend towards public service, organisation, local politics, communal resources, electoral experiences and historical memory. The narrative allows us to examine the difference between service-oriented individuals, public reputation and political claims. A discussion that begins with civic problems in Delhi reaches the workings of institutions. Through this expansion, many themes from the preceding eight sections are brought together again.

The section alludes to events of the twentieth century and, in particular, discusses political and social memories associated with 1984. Such material should be read as the memory and viewpoint of a literary character; independent historical corroboration would require separate contemporary documents. The book's ethical concern is with the public good, civic participation and opposition to exploitation, but some of its assessments of historical figures may also risk one-sidedness.

One creative accomplishment of the extended ninth section is that the public park develops from a setting for private conversation into a wider

political community. At the same time, a question of craft arises: the discussions grow so extensive that the scene, the characters and the physical experience of place may recede. Nevertheless, on the final printed page, the conclusion of the conversation with Raghuvansh Babu and the recollection of the author's stay in Delhi bring the circle of the book to a close.

Character Design and the Narrator's Position

Shyam Babu, Khushwant Singh, Ajay Babu, Khanna Sahib, Sudhakarji, Ramanji, Dr Kiran, Budhna and Raghuvansh Babu emerge not merely as separate individuals but as representative perspectives on social experience. The movement from character to character encompasses different linguistic, professional, class and generational positions. Through their combination, the author reveals the diversity within Delhi itself.

The narrator is generally a curious fellow participant. He questions the characters, advances arguments, disagrees, and then moves on to the next episode in agreement or disagreement. This conversational design draws the reader into reflection rather than leaving the reader a passive spectator. Yet the narrator often assumes a definitive moral position; as a consequence, dissenting characters cannot fully express the complexity of their own views. A critical reading of the book must always distinguish the author's opinions from the social positions of the characters.

Language, Speech and the Rhythm of Dialogue

The book's principal linguistic strength is its dialogue-driven Maithili. Sentence structures formed by memories of rural experience, interrogative expressions, colloquial replies, humour and the vocabulary of daily life animate the narrative. Given Delhi's multilingual context, influences from Punjabi, Hindi and English, as well as administrative and professional terminology, naturally appear. This mixture is not, without further examination, a form of "linguistic impurity"; it signals the public linguistic life of a metropolis.

The recurrence of questions between speakers gives the text an audible quality; the book lends itself to reading aloud as individual scenes, dramatic recitation or audio presentation. Extended monologues, however, obstruct the natural movement of conversation. Greater variation in vocabulary, gesture and intonation according to the characters' ages, professions and regions would have intensified the artistic effect of the literary sketch. At certain points more subtle irony and silence might have replaced didactic conclusions.

Village–City Relations: Memory, Convenience and Unequal Opportunity

The central conflict of Delhi Ke Park is not a simple opposition between village and city. The village suggests intimacy, tradition, belonging and memory; the city offers possibilities of employment, education, medical care, safety, mobility and coexistence among numerous languages. One place offers readily available relationships but limited opportunities; the other offers wider opportunities, while relationships may be anonymous or formal. The author

sympathises with the village in this tension, yet the importance of economic causes repeatedly emerges within the telling itself.

A particularly valuable social question posed by the work concerns the form in which a migrant imagines obligations towards the native village. Returning regularly is not enough: how are structures of education, healthcare, water, livelihoods, public conduct and cooperation to be changed there? Not all retired people can follow the same course. The work's value therefore lies less in any prescribed solution than in making questions from diverse experiences of life subjects of public debate.

A significant absence is also visible. Women's labour in the village, landless families, the experiences of different castes and classes, working women's perspectives and the voices of urban women workers receive comparatively little sustained attention. There are numerous examples involving families and children, but women characters' independent experiences are not accorded equal space. Without acknowledging this limitation, it would be an exaggeration to accept the image of the "village" as a single, unified collective.

Civic Public Life: The Meaning of the Park and the Limits of Democracy

The park's significance as a public space deserves special attention. Hierarchies of employment do not immediately determine relationships here: retired employees, teachers, doctors, people associated with administrative services and individuals from other backgrounds can converse on the same bench. This verbal public sphere is a miniature image of civil society. Widening one's circle of acquaintance, listening to different opinions and establishing trust with strangers are cultural achievements of the place.

Sharing the same physical space, however, does not automatically mean possessing equal resources. Voices already influential in society are likely to be heard more prominently in debates in the park as well. The dominance of educated older men in Delhi Ke Park is therefore worth considering. This does not diminish the work's importance; rather, it raises a question about those who remain silent in the park—working women, attendants, anxious young people and migrant labourers. This critical gap suggests fresh possibilities for future Maithili writing about urban life.

Comparison with the History of Children's Literature: Generic Difference and a Bridge between Readerships

It would be inappropriate to identify Delhi Ke Park directly as a children's book in the history of children's literature. First, the book describes itself as a literary sketch. Second, its extended social and political conversations primarily address adult readers. Third, the central concern is not the independent development of a child character's experience but the older generation's memories and civic arguments. The sound basis of comparison is therefore genre, the educational use of dialogue and changing social knowledge about village and city—not automatic inclusion in the canon of children's literature.

Videha's "Shishu Utsav" book catalogue lists several distinct strands together: children's poetry, illustrated stories, folktales, comics, children's novels, science fiction, translated illustrated stories and young-adult literature. The bibliographic descriptions of Preeti Thakur's Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Picture Stories (2008), Maithili Picture Stories (2009), Folk Deities of Mithila (2010), Vidyapati's Purush Pariksha (2012), and her series of translated picture stories suggest a trajectory in visually based and translated reading materials for children. These publication years are those specified in Videha's catalogue; they are not independent historical evidence for the origins or earliest examples of Maithili children's literature as a whole.

The Videha list likewise mentions Chonha by Jagadanand Jha 'Manu'; Taregan and Nai Dhaaraie by Jagdish Prasad Mandal; Swarna Kamal by Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'; Munna Ji's Three Children's Plays and Khurluchchi; Hamar Gaam and Pyramid Ke Desh Me by Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi'; and several children's and young-adult novels by Gajendra Thakur. These titles demonstrate an expansion in linguistic resources available to young children, older children and adolescents. No judgement about these books' plots, character development or aesthetic superiority has been reached here merely by consulting their bibliographic entries.

Swarna Kamal and Delhi Ke Park are examples of different genres within the same author's bibliography. The former appears as a children's novel in Videha's children's-literature section, while the latter appears as a literary sketch in its book section. The critical significance of the distinction is that Nand's readership is not restricted to a single age group or genre. The linguistic vitality, companionship, family responsibility and questions of the village in Delhi Ke Park could furnish selected topics for discussion among adolescent readers; but the suitability of the entire work for children cannot be assumed. Adaptation for a particular age group would need to retain the complexity of the social debates while broadening the range of experience represented.

Another important aspect of this comparative history is the transformation of the medium. Stories and illustrated books for children attend to a child's visual and auditory reception, while Delhi Ke Park unfolds as a sustained sequence of audible civic conversations. This distinction shows that the history of children's literature concerns not merely the number of books but also readers' ages, the role of images, accessibility of language, diversity of voices and modes of participation. By this criterion Delhi Ke Park is not a competitor to children's literature but a comparative boundary text grounded in adult civic conversation.

Aesthetic Achievements and Critical Objections

The work's principal achievements are, first, connecting Delhi's urban experience with memories of villages in Mithila; second, transforming a public park into a living site of multilingual popular dialogue; third, portraying post-retirement life as reflective rather than inert; fourth, revealing the differences between personal experiences across professions; and

fifth, treating social responsibility as a question distinct from private prosperity. The book also has historical value in its archival character as a record of social experience: it offers imaginative testimony to migrant Maithili sensibilities in Delhi at a particular moment, though it cannot replace statistical history.

Three principal objections stand alongside these achievements. First, didactic elaboration frequently diminishes the creation of scenes and dramatic concision. Second, the characters' ideological positions sometimes become vehicles for the author's fixed conclusions, limiting genuine clashes between differing voices. Third, the social world centres on the perspectives of educated older men; a denser presence of workers, women's experience and the younger generation's direct voices could have made its social portrait more comprehensive. These objections do not amount to an argument for rejecting the work; they constitute a realistic assessment of its artistic potential.

Conclusion

Delhi Ke Park is a significant conversational experiment in representing urban migration through the Maithili literary sketch. Its nine sections begin with memories of the village and the daily life of retired people and end with civic institutions, social ethics and political memory. This expansion makes the book's social aspirations clear. At its best, ordinary conversations in the park become serious questions about collective life; in its less successful passages, discursive elaboration overshadows the art of making scenes visible.

The work's lasting contribution lies not in any single conclusion favouring the village but in repeatedly asking how people living in modern cities understand their responsibilities towards their language, native village, family and wider society. Comparison with bibliographies of children's literature makes clear that the same social questions can assume different forms in different readerships of Maithili prose. Delhi Ke Park therefore properly belongs to the literary sketch of adult civic dialogue; it should be studied with literary form, social context and critical distance kept together.

Chapter 9

Yachak Ke Nahi (Who Is Not a Supplicant?)

From Visible Begging to the Power Structures of Invisible Supplication

At first glance, Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Yachak Ke Nahi begins with society's dismissive attitude towards beggars. Gradually, however, it exposes a moral inequality under which the visible beggar is condemned while soliciting favour through office, connections, recommendations, patronage, contracts or political advantage becomes a mark of prestige. Published in 2022, this Maithili literary sketch has nine numbered sections. Its narrative time, the movement of characters and the unfolding of Subhan Bhai's social experience make it not a collection of independent portraits but a progressively developed, dialogue-driven satirical narrative. The central argument of this essay is that the work's principal aesthetic quality lies in its expansion of the meaning of "supplicant": supplication is not

confined to asking with a begging bowl, for persistently seeking favour from institutions that control resources can also constitute a social form of begging.

The essay first examines the work's genre, title, narrative perspective, character structure, linguistic registers, humour and satire, and social history. It then offers separate readings of the nine sections on printed pages 15–116, following their original order. Comparison with children's literature does not misclassify the work as a children's novel; rather, it considers differences in educational purpose, language and readership between this work, Nand's Swarna Kamal, and the tradition of writing for children and adolescents documented in Videha's Shishu Utsav. The sources used include Videha's book catalogue, research index, criticism available in the author's collected works, and relevant records of children's literature.

Entering the Subject: The Question in the Title and the Central Critical Proposition

The title Yachak Ke Nahi is interrogative in its grammatical structure. It asks not only who the supplicants are, but also who is not one. Society does not view in the same way the demands of a visible beggar, an impoverished worker, an unemployed young person, a small shopkeeper, an official, a politician or an intermediary protected by power. By distinguishing economic need, deprivation of rights, the pursuit of favour and the brokerage of advantages, the author attacks the moral classification of the act of "asking." This distinction remains a structural thread from the opening discussion of beggars to the question entrusted to the reader's judgement on the final printed page. [1, printed pp. 15–25, 108–116]

A fundamental textual precaution is necessary in assessing the work's literary significance. The title's Devanagari form contains "नञि" (nahi, "not"); the romanised publishing form is "Yachak ke Nai." To read romanised "Nai" as "new" without consulting the original script would destroy the book's negative and interrogative suggestiveness. Videha's book catalogue records the Devanagari title as Yachak Ke Nahi. This study therefore respects the original title and places the negative "not" at the centre of its interpretation. [1, title page; 2]

Subhan Bhai is a continuously present character. His life connections, relatives, acquaintances, employment and relationships with institutions are gradually revealed. Alongside him, the presence of a narrative-conducting "protagonist" repeatedly reminds readers that this is not a literal transcription of society but a literary presentation made from selected scenes, questions, conversations and viewpoints. A "literary sketch" here is not a motionless picture: it brings together multiple scenes to produce a social outline.

Publication, Textual Extent and Method of Evidence

The original publication details identify Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand' as author and Gosaauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch (Uparadaha, Darbhanga district) as publisher; they give 2022 as the first-edition year and ₹200 as the stated contribution. After an opening dedication, an appreciative foreword

and the author's introductory note, the main text begins on printed page 15 and ends on page 116. The nine sections begin respectively on printed pages 15, 26, 43, 55, 62, 76, 90, 102 and 108. [1, preliminary publication pages; pp. 15–116]

A limitation concerning textual evidence needs to be made explicit. The beginnings of sections, characters, episodes and sequence of events have been examined, but no conjectural wording has been presented as a direct quotation.

"Literary sketch" is the genre the book declares for itself; its introductory discussion places its scale near the boundaries of portrait, narrative and novel. Critical study treats classifications proposed by the author or foreword writer not as final instructions but as propositions to be tested against the structure of the text. This matters because the nine sections do not constitute nine entirely self-contained portraits: they exhibit the gradual expansion of a principal social world. [1, foreword: printed pp. 5–12; main text: pp. 15–116]

Generic Form: The Literary Sketch, Narrative Portrait and the Border of the Short Novel

The language of a literary sketch draws more than a person's exterior outline: it reveals the individual's manner of conduct, social position, differences between speech and action, and the network of relationships around them. A conventional portrait may concentrate upon one individual or moment; here, however, causal sequences in the characters' lives, the intervention of social institutions and recurring conversations combine to make a narrative world. It is therefore more meaningful to call the work a "narrative literary sketch."

The storyteller repeatedly moves from what a character says to description, and from description to new dialogue. Narrative time does not flow at a uniform speed in this recurrence: at moments, an earlier event is incorporated as life history; at others, a present-day encounter instantly turns into a political discussion. The numbering of sections gives readers a sense of stages, but characters and circumstances from one episode continue entering another. To regard the work as "nine separate stories" would therefore fracture its internal relationships.

This generic experiment has limitations as well. As incidents accumulate, some characters appear briefly, serving only as examples; the author's social pronouncements sometimes outweigh the natural movement of the scene. Nevertheless, demanding the complete structural discipline of a short novel would be inappropriate: the selectivity of the literary sketch allows the author to arrange varied angles on social life around one dominant subject. This oscillation should be understood not merely as a weakness but as a creative challenge within the work.

Separate Analyses Following the Original Arrangement of Nine Sections

Section One: The Visible Beggar and Inequality of Respect

The first section begins by identifying the harshness of society's gaze: a beggar becomes an object of contempt, while people occupying far higher social positions also depend upon others to fulfil their needs. Religious utterance, the cultural standing of alms, economic compulsion and social indifference enter the same discussion. The narrator asks for more than compassion; he asks readers to look again by changing the meaning they attach to a word.

Here the author constructs a moral contradiction. An ordinary beggar's bowl is visible; the "bowl" of someone seeking favours close to office or power remains concealed within prestige, acquaintance and recommendation. The distinction between supplication and labour, between charity and entitlement, and the relation of dependence to self-respect are introduced in the first section. Its answers are not offered as an immediate moral lesson: the work invites readers to test them against the episodes to come.

In terms of craft, the first section moves from a conceptual opening towards experience grounded in characters. Its strength lies in raising a contentious question; its limitation is that the initial proposition can occasionally sound didactic. Even so, the opening establishes the central connection between the title and the final question.

Section Two: Subhan Bhai's World and the Struggle for a Livelihood

In the second section, Subhan Bhai emerges as the narrative's living centre. His ordinariness—lacking influence from household to household, enduring prosperity or institutional security—is remarkable because the author reaches large social questions through the experience of an ordinary person concerned with earning a living, rather than that of a supposedly "great man." References to flowers and leaves, household work, petty employment, family responsibilities and advice from acquaintances provide a material foundation for his life. [1, pp. 26–42]

The abundance of dialogue reveals different perspectives across social classes. Subhan Bhai weighs self-help, hard work and possibilities, while others suggest immediate employment, useful contacts, benefits or routes towards social advancement. For the author, this distinction demonstrates that unemployment is not merely an economic crisis but also a cultural one: the absence of employment diminishes not only income but also alters society's standards of respect.

The section's artistic effect arises from small details of lived experience. Even where moral instruction is frequent, these details give it a grounding in reality. They also show that Subhan Bhai's difficulties are not solely matters of individual struggle; they are the result of a lack of resources and the unequal distribution of opportunity.

Section Three: Acquaintance, Identity and the Language of Mediation

The third section makes the debate about social acquaintance and personal connections more explicit. Amid the protagonist's questions and answers arise issues of names, occupations, appearance, addresses and trust. Those who want help are seen concealing their actual identities or presenting them only in part. [1, pp. 43–54]

At this level, the "supplicant" ceases to denote merely the economic condition of a beggar and enters the conduct of people trying to establish social connections. Can any work be accomplished without a recommendation? How wide is the gap between what people say and what they do? Do those offering help genuinely accept responsibility, or take advantage of a social opportunity? These questions move the narrative forward.

From an artistic perspective, the third section is distinguished by tension in its dialogue. An immediate answer seldom settles the issue; more often, it generates fresh uncertainty. This uncertainty increases the story's realism. Yet repeated counter-questions on the same point can also produce a sense of repetition.

Section Four: Suleman's Labour, Trust and Means of Subsistence

The fourth section opens with questions of trust, confidentiality and doing good for others. The small enterprise of a character named Suleman, his work repairing bicycles, and his dealings with other people are notable here. The daily routine of an impoverished worker is not an incidental colour detached from the main action; it supplies an alternative measure of social dignity. [1, pp. 55–61]

The discussion of possibilities for labour among people who beg gives the section further moral density. Rather than treating an immediate donation as the answer, the narrative raises more enduring questions of participation in work, secure livelihoods and social trust. Yet this possibility also reveals a limit: the text does not establish that everyone who begs can readily shift into agriculture or private enterprise. Health, age, land, capital and conditions of social discrimination require separate consideration.

This section displays the work's humanistic commitment. The proximity between Suleman's culture of work and Subhan Bhai's social outlook offers a perspective of actual coexistence instead of an easy opposition based on religion. That is a considerable social achievement.

Section Five: The Small Shopkeeper, Railway Administration and the System of Favours

In the fifth section, the small paan business of a low-income man named Dinu and the setting of a railway station open up a new field of power relations. The fate of a business dependent on daily earnings is tied not merely to individual competence but to official inspections, permissions, informal instructions, middlemen and local influence. Episodes involving Lalbabu and

people associated with the railway establishment give these obstacles narrative form. [1, pp. 62–75]

The section's importance lies not in general denunciations of "corruption" but in the depiction of its everyday economic effects. For someone earning very little, the closure of an opportunity is not a one-time financial loss: it affects an entire family's food, dignity and future. The helplessness of a person caught between formal administrative rules and customary pressures becomes a modern image of social disadvantage.

Artistically, this section turns the preceding philosophical question into an administrative example. Its satire becomes most forceful when someone who earns a living through hard work is compelled to supplicate for permission and favour, while a person holding office can market his patronage as a resource. Nevertheless, the narrative should not be mistaken for a complete record of actual governmental procedures. It is a literary reconstruction in which institutions are criticised through a character's experience.

Section Six: Family, Belonging and Expectations of Employment

The sixth section introduces a fuller picture of Subhan Bhai's family life. With references to Jamila Begum and other family members, the work's social questions become questions of domestic need, care and affection. Concern for the family's future security is linked to the discussion of job information, applications, eligibility, examinations and connections with officials. [1, pp. 76–89]

What particularly deserves attention here is the extent to which a family's hopes depend upon decisions made by other people. If this dependence is secured within lawful entitlements, it is a form of equal citizenship; but if recommendations and vested interests become indispensable intermediaries, they produce a mentality of supplication. The author's satire operates within this fine distinction.

Women characters give the narrative an emotional foundation, but a critical question is necessary here: how far does the narrator allow us to hear their own wishes, decisions and work, and how far do they simply form the background to portraits of male characters? The development of women's independent inner voices is limited in this text; this shortcoming in craft should be recorded alongside its criticism of social reality.

Section Seven: Elections, Money and the Displacement of the Public Good

The seventh section enters the political sphere. Subhan Bhai's desire to undertake public work, contacts with representatives, demands for election expenditure and signs of improper pressure reveal a gulf between democracy's fundamental idea and the practical use made of it. An episode involving a legislator and negotiations over money creates the main opposition in the narrative. [1, pp. 90–101]

The position of the "supplicant" is reversed here. A public representative ought to be the servant of citizens, yet arrangements may become such that

citizens must approach that representative with money, votes or personal pleas in order to receive services. In criticising political patronage, the author's satire does not reject democratic institutions altogether; it opposes private ownership over services and benefits meant for the public.

The section's achievement is to show social problems as products of decisions and the distribution of power rather than of uncontrollable destiny. Nevertheless, the narrative does not establish the sweeping proposition that all political activity consists of corrupt bargains. It is more balanced to read the author's particular depiction as an example through which a larger institutional question is posed.

Section Eight: Official Power and the Proposal of a Moral Compromise

The eighth section is comparatively brief, but it intensifies the narrative's moral concerns. In a conversation between Subhan Bhai and Raunak, they discuss the influence of a government officeholder, the formal path through which work is done, and intermediary methods serving private gain. Raunak's reply transforms the episode into a moral test between personal interest and the pursuit of improper advantage. [1, pp. 102–107]

Despite its brevity, the section's satirical implication is effective. Wherever the institutional boundary between "doing a job" and "getting a job done through influence" collapses, a private market in favours arises. The desire to obtain services through personal connections can gradually turn a citizen's consciousness of rights into the mentality of someone seeking patronage.

One limitation is that, in certain sensitive social episodes, women remain subjects of discussion or objects of requests; the narrator's critical distance is not always equally clear. A rigorous examination of gender ethics is therefore necessary, otherwise the question of women's autonomy may be suppressed within satire directed against officials.

Section Nine: Raunak, Family and the Final Reversal of the Question of Supplication

The last section brings to the fore the complexities of a social prestige centred on employment through Raunak's difficulties, family expectations, questions of marriage and episodes concerning a character named Seema. Political and administrative connections reach into decisions concerning domestic life. Conversation within the family shows the reader that the pressures of power relations can extend into the domain of private desires. [1, pp. 108–116]

The ninth section's most important action is its return to the title. The question initially focused on a visible beggar returns in reverse at the end, confronting the reader. The social attitude that humiliates the ordinary beggar and the educated, prosperous world that seeks favours from powerful offices are brought into a single moral comparison. The final question does not turn the work into a fully explained manifesto; it expects a judgement from the reader.

The last scene allows the structure of the entire work to be seen anew: the first section establishes an explanatory premise; the middle sections successively reveal "social forms of supplication" in different institutions; and the final section leaves the decision about a new designation to the reader. This open suggestiveness is the ending's aesthetic strength. Some transitions between events are nevertheless rather abrupt; accepting this uneven rhythm does not invalidate the intellectual force of the final question.

Character Design: Subhan Bhai, the Protagonist, Raunak and the Social World

Subhan Bhai is the emotional centre of this literary sketch. He appears at once as a social philosopher, an ordinary person concerned with earning a living, someone responsible for his family, and a character who can envisage the possibility of social change. By bringing these aspects together, the author avoids glorifying an entirely idealised hero. Subhan Bhai's strength lies not in his perfection but in his attempts to understand his circumstances despite having limited resources. The address "Bhai" attached to his name signals affection and the coexistence characteristic of everyday speech.

The protagonist performs the function of directing the discourse. He asks questions within the narrative, changes the subject, listens to others and sometimes adds his own commentary. This witness-like structure allows readers to hear the thoughts of the people involved rather than merely a moral announcement delivered from above. Yet the extent to which the storyteller's opinions differ from the protagonist's is not always clear; because of this ambiguity, readers may adopt certain political conclusions without sufficient critical distance.

Raunak is associated with an advancing social position, professional opportunities and moral risks. Women's participation provides a basis for the family's social anxieties, but how much independent narrative development do they receive with regard to their ability to decide, their livelihood and their aspirations? This remains a significant question. Through individual portraits, characters such as Suleman and Dinu reveal the difficulties of the informal economy; Lalbabu and the official class become figures for the personal appropriation of power.

The social and cultural variety of the names is noteworthy. Subhan, Suleman and Jamila appear in the same narrative world alongside characters from different communities and institutional backgrounds. This linguistic and cultural coexistence is a strength of the work; rather than treating it as idealised proof of social harmony, however, it is more meaningful to emphasise the questions of "shared insecurity" and "shared labour" that it contains.

Thematic Analysis: Alms, Labour, Rights and Patronage

The book can be understood through four levels of argument. The first is "visible alms-seeking," practised by people who are socially despised. The

second is "necessity of livelihood," where unemployed people, shopkeepers and workers come to depend on the goodwill of institutions empowered to decide their fates. The third is "political patronage," where access or money affects the distribution of services and opportunities. The fourth is "moral hypocrisy," under which the first kind of request is treated as disgraceful while the other three kinds of supplication may be regarded as marks of prestige.

This categorisation reconstructs the book's social insight; it is not a proposal to force every event in the narrative into a fixed formula. The work becomes especially significant when it does not seek merely to preserve a system of charity through pity, but questions relations among livelihood, social justice, access to services and citizens' rights. The image of the "poor beggar" becomes an occasion to understand structural conditions rather than evidence of moral deficiency.

From the perspective of social economics, the underlying problem of supplication is unequal control of resources. Where many people depend upon a small number of opportunities, the discretionary power of those who allocate them increases. Informal payments, personal acquaintance, recommendations and political affiliations may themselves become an additional currency. The narrative shows the moral consequences of this extra currency. It does not follow, however, that every form of help is unjust; distinguishing assistance grounded in rights from the bargaining of favours is essential to its interpretation.

The Art of Language: Folk Rhythm, Verbal Satire and the Aesthetics of Repetition

The language derives its fundamental energy from popular conversation. The characters' questions, immediate objections, forms of address and comments dictated by circumstance give movement to the narrative. An address such as "Bhai" reduces social distance; practical words referring to railways, stations, offices, contracts, elections, jobs and paan shops establish a realistic geography of experience. This linguistic inclusiveness makes Maithili a capable literary medium for the discussion of contemporary administrative and civic life.

Its principal rhetorical device is paradox: the powerless person is ridiculed while the influential one is admired; the worker is mistrusted while the broker of favours is respected in society. The negative question in the title forms the focal point of this paradox. A subdued current of compassion also runs beside the satire of the dialogue. Humour and compassion do not cancel each other out in the emotional world of the work; by disclosing the social causes of suffering, humour gives questioning its force.

A limitation of its craft can be found in repetition. Multiple versions of the same question, repeated statements of a character's social opinions and didactic declarations about institutional faults sometimes diminish the narrative's momentum. Yet continuous questioning and answering are also part of this work's natural oral mode. Editorial reduction of unnecessary

repetition could have increased the narrative's intellectual sharpness, although the repetition also preserves the authentic rhythm of popular dispute.

Ethical Criticism: Literary Achievements and Questionable Aspects

The work's greatest achievement is its exposure of double standards in social morality. Through the characters' connections and acquaintances, the author establishes that, amid unequal relations of power, "asking" itself becomes an action marked by class. A poor person's demand is unacceptable while the powerful person's request passes unquestioned: this comparison sharpens social criticism. Moreover, the author refuses to make occupation or office the sole basis of human dignity; he attaches importance to labour and social responsibility.

The work is nevertheless not beyond criticism. First, certain episodes fail to explore the full range of causes of begging: disability, illness, insecurity among children, elderly dependence and state social-security policy receive limited attention. Second, its representation of government largely emerges through the experiences of opportunistic individuals; affirmative examples or exceptions grounded in legal rights are scarce. Third, the voices of women generally revolve around the struggles of male characters. Fourth, its satire of political episodes sometimes rests more heavily upon personal morality than upon structural analysis.

These limitations arise from an internal examination of the text, not from a wish to reject the author's social commitment. A genuine evaluation of socially engaged literature must consider not only the moral sincerity of its perspective but also its ability to portray the complexity of actual circumstances. By this measure, Yachak Ke Nahi is more powerful in raising questions than in providing comprehensive solutions, whether deliberately or for reasons of craft. A dimension of its modernity lies precisely in this incompleteness.

Its Place in Maithili Literary History: A Parallel Readerly Perspective

A history of Maithili literature cannot adequately be written by concentrating only on prestigious poetic forms or award-winning novels. The literary transformation of ordinary people's livelihoods, small markets, railway stations, local brokerage, the conduct of public representatives and familial hopes is also material for the history of modern Maithili prose. Nand's literary sketch can therefore be approached not merely as a subsidiary genre of fiction but as literary testimony to social history. Such testimony does not substitute for documentary facts: the narrative's value lies in its organisation of social sensibility.

Videha's work on parallel literary history has raised questions concerning neglected writers, popular language, narrative forms and systems of publication. Videha's comprehensive critical study of Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand' identifies him as a writer working across genres: the social novel, literary sketch, short story, poetry and children's novel all belong to this

range. The usefulness of this classification here is to show that Yachak Ke Nahi is not an incomplete shadow of a children's novel but an independent experiment in his social prose.

A textual correction is also necessary. It is doubtful to derive a meaning such as "new petitioner" from the romanised title "Yachak ke Nai." When the presence of "नञि" ("not") in the original Devanagari is considered alongside the narrative's concluding question, the negative-interrogative reading is more consistent. The original title page must therefore take precedence when bibliographies, translations and criticism differ. The accuracy of literary history depends not only on large theoretical propositions but also upon such small textual decisions.

A Comparative Examination of the History of Children's Literature: Generic Boundaries and Shared Social Concerns

First, Acknowledge the Generic Difference

Yachak Ke Nahi is a literary sketch; neither its title page nor its available narrative structure substantiates a claim that it was written specifically for an age-defined readership of children. Placing it directly in a children's-literature catalogue would therefore be a category error. Comparison with the history of children's literature is not, however, irrelevant. Nand's other work, Swarna Kamal, is explicitly catalogued as a "children's novel" in Videha's Shishu Utsav. The social literary sketch and the children's novel by the same writer may differ in their intended readers, pace of narration, density of language and representation of moral questions.

For children's stories, the reader's age, range of experience, visual coherence, active child characters and opportunities to ask questions are distinctive criteria. Yachak Ke Nahi contains mature examples drawn from politics, administrative bargaining, the struggle for employment and moral hypocrisy. This material could be adapted to cultivate adolescents' social understanding, but nothing establishes that the original work in its present form was written for early readers.

Indications of the Development of Children's Literature in the Videha Archive

Videha's Shishu Utsav and book records reveal the varied forms of contemporary Maithili children's literature. Collections based on folktales, illustrated stories, children's poetry, children's novels, plays, books on scientific subjects and translated illustrated literature appear in separate categories. The available catalogue records Preeti Thakur's Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Picture Stories (2008), Maithili Picture Stories (2009), Folk Deities of Mithila (2010) and the adaptation for children of Vidyapati's Purush Pariksha (2012). These examples suggest connections among oral traditions, visually based reading and cultural narratives.

Videha's research index records Phoolchandra Jha 'Praveen's "Maithili Shishu Lok Sahitya" (issue 50, 15 January 2010); Dr Yoganand Jha's "Maithili

Ballokkatha: Sthiti Aa Apeksha" (issue 76, 15 February 2011); and Durganand Mandal's "Nena Lel Sundar Chitrakatha" (issue 116, 15 October 2012). The sequence of these three titles indicates the presence in literary discussion of questions about oral folk material, collections and criticism of picture stories. Only their archival titles, authors, issue numbers and dates are verified here; their particular arguments have not been quoted without separately examining the original essays.

In subsequent developments, children's literature has not remained confined to moral tales. Videha's catalogue includes children's novels and short inspirational tales by Jagdish Prasad Mandal, short stories and illustrated works addressing science and society by Nita Jha, discussions of science by Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi', children's and young-adult novels by Gajendra Thakur, and references to plays and activities for children and adolescents. The 2026 publication Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra (A Critical Theory of the Maithili Children's Novel) examines several children's novels through criteria such as rasa, propriety, folk narrative, children's agency and visual narration. Such work-centred examples demonstrate possibilities for contemporary scholarship, not a final or exhaustive history of all Maithili children's literature.

Swarna Kamal and Yachak Ke Nahi: Purpose, Reader and Form

The appearance of Nand's Swarna Kamal as a children's novel in Videha's catalogue and the designation of Yachak Ke Nahi as a literary sketch indicate two reading worlds within one writer's oeuvre. In a children's novel, narrative excitement, a child's curiosity, clear motivations for characters' actions and visually evocative language have particular purposes. In Yachak Ke Nahi, the complex social meanings of labour, power and supplication matter more; the characters' exchanges gradually form a satire of institutions.

Where, then, is the similarity? Both kinds of literature can help to shape social sensibility. Seeing injustice from a child's perspective and understanding its institutional forms from an adult perspective are different literary paths. Social dignity, respect for hard work, sympathy for the vulnerable and the right to ask questions may be shared values along these paths. The presence of common values alone, however, does not establish generic identity.

If selected passages of this literary sketch are adapted for an adolescent curriculum, it will be necessary to respect young readers' actual experience, employ scene-based presentation, supply explanations of difficult vocabulary, incorporate women characters' perspectives and maintain the distinction between factual and literary writing. The more responsible approach would be to place the adult language and critical difficulties of the political episodes in context, rather than erase them.

Children's Moral Education and Adult-Centred Didacticism

A fundamental question in criticism of literature for children or adolescents is whether children construct meanings for themselves or whether an adult writer supplies ready-made answers. Yachak Ke Nahi challenges

readers with its final question, an approach valuable to inquiry-led education. Nevertheless, many sections contain elaborate moral explanations from adults speaking through the characters; this differs from the concise, visually grounded, child-centred narration associated with children's literature.

Videha's 2026 critical study of children's novels includes children's agency, reinterpretation of folk narratives, appropriate presentation of subject matter and criticism of social taboos among its topics. Viewed in this light, Nand's literary sketch provides a conceptual comparison for children's literature: it should open not only the instruction "Help the poor" but also the question "Why do people remain poor?" This is a comparative conclusion about the ethical capacity of children's literature, not a classification of this work as children's literature.

Rasa, Suggestion and Readerly Engagement

The rasa of compassion arises here not simply from depicting poverty but from exposing the social humiliation attached to it. When readers encounter two contrasting social responses to comparable requests for favour, compassion becomes a form of discernment. Humour is principally satirical; by questioning assumptions about social prestige, it makes compassion more acute. The joining of these emotional currents is central to the book's intellectual artistry.

The principal source of suggestion is the uncertain address embodied in the title. "Supplicant" does not remain a fixed social category; each new episode changes its meaning. Thus the reader is not handed a single meaning but shown the boundaries of an earlier one. Linguistically, the negative question is the work's most effective symbolic device.

Readers may answer that question differently: is the issue an individual's moral weakness, a corrupt institution, society's system of prestige, or dependence produced by economic uncertainty? The literary value of the work lies in the fact that these questions are entangled. A clear, single-line moral formula does not displace the indirect social conflict.

Conclusion: The Beggar We See, the Supplication We Do Not and Literature's Ethical Vision

The literary achievement of Yachak Ke Nahi lies in the structure through which it tests one question from its title against multiple social situations. Its opening treatment of beggars, Subhan Bhai's struggle for a livelihood, Suleman's labour, Dinu's petty trade, railway permissions, precarious employment, political bargaining, Raunak's professional difficulties and the final family complications are all different forms of the same social question: how secure are a person's rights when the necessities of life are subject to another's arbitrary control?

Close examination of the nine sections makes clear that the work is essentially an extended, progressively developed literary sketch—neither a children's novel nor merely an irregular collection of separate portraits. Its

popular cadence, social satire and dialogue among characters make it valuable prose; verbal repetition, occasionally extended didacticism, the restricted autonomy of women characters and one-sided accounts of institutional procedures constitute its critical limitations.

Its significance in comparison with the history of Maithili children's literature lies in clarifying a boundary. In intended age group, artistic form and social analysis, it differs from a work for children such as Nand's Swarna Kamal. Yet concern for the dignity of vulnerable people, courage in asking questions and respect for labour allow meaningful conversation between the two literary domains. Videha's records offer a historical basis for understanding these relationships among genres.

Ultimately, the book's fundamental question is not resolved by declaring one category of human beings "beggars." Its wider significance lies in correcting the way society sees: why does the appeal of the weak become grounds for humiliation while a powerful person's pursuit of favour receives respect? Keeping this uncomfortable question alive is the enduring literary strength of Yachak Ke Nahi.

Notes on Textual Evidence and Edition

(b) The nine sections begin respectively on printed pages 15, 26, 43, 55, 62, 76, 90, 102 and 108. In the separate analyses, each section is understood to end immediately before the next begins.

(c) This essay follows the original Devanagari title "याचक के नजि." The published romanisation "YACH(A)K KE NAI" does not itself establish the precise English meaning of the negative expression; its contextual interpretation is based on the original Devanagari title and the ending.

Printed page ranges have nonetheless been linked to the arguments so that researchers can check the lines again against the original printed copy.

Chapter 10

Maharani Kaikeyi (Queen Kaikeyi)

Rereading Myth, Women's Agency and Moral Reconsideration

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Maharani Kaikeyi is a discursive essay developed in ten sections that challenges the familiar image of Kaikeyi grounded in the assignment of blame within the Ramayana. Instead of depicting her as a greedy stepmother or the destroyer of a royal dynasty, the work attempts to establish her as a figure of political foresight, maternal affection, sacrifice and concern for the public good. Its central argument is that Rama's exile should not be regarded simply as the outcome of revenge or excessive attachment to a son, but viewed against the background of a complex national and cultural crisis, Rama's future mission and a measure of family agreement. This study follows the ten sections in sequence, examining the author's mode of argument, use of classical narrative and later poetry, linguistic strategies of character defence, and the evidential limits of an alternative reading. In its comparison with children's literature, it preserves the generic difference between the essay and the children's novel while

considering the educational potential of retelling myths and the danger of moral oversimplification. The conclusion is that the work is a bold intervention in Maithili reconsiderations of myth, although it must still confront questions of evidence and interpretative plurality.

Setting the Question: From Villain to the Centre of Debate

Whenever Rama's exile is recounted, Kaikeyi's name emerges in popular memory as a symbol of blame. In most familiar retellings, the political event, religious obligation and family tragedy are compressed into one cause: Kaikeyi's demand for boons. Within this simple chain of causation, her personality, experience of crisis and possible judgement disappear. Nand Kumar Mishra begins his argument by challenging this tradition of accusation. His purpose is not simply to generate a little sympathy for the character; he calls for the moral distribution of responsibility in the Ramayana to be read afresh.

The literary importance of this appeal may be seen at two levels. First, the author directs attention to a character without whom the principal narrative could not unfold, yet whose inner motives are usually interpreted in a single way. Second, he seeks to relocate the cause of the action from personal ill will to a complex relationship among royal succession, military and cultural crisis, maternal duty and collective welfare. In this form, Maharani Kaikeyi becomes not so much an essay that retells a story as one that invites thought about the story.

A precaution is essential here. To treat any one version of the Ramayana as the sole authoritative text for every version would contradict the principles of comparative study. The author constructs his model of Kaikeyi with the help of Valmiki, Tulsidas and later interpretative poetry. His conclusion must therefore be tested as an alternative interpretative proposal presented within a text, not as an independently established historical fact. This distinction illuminates both the work's achievement and its limitations.

The Work, Its Genre and Basic Structure

The available printed copy of Maharani Kaikeyi names Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand' as its author. The preliminary publishing information mentions publishing assistance and printing in the Darbhanga region; the author's concluding note is dated 17 September 2008. This gives an indication of the period of composition but does not establish the year in which the book was printed. The main text occupies printed pages 1–48. It is accompanied by a preliminary cover, dedication, author's note and final biographical introduction.

The book's generic identity is important. It does not display the continuous event sequence of a children's novel, distinct dramatic acts or the fully developed form of a story dominated by dialogue. Instead, the author chiefly sets out his position, introduces passages of ancient verse and later poetic references, and uses these materials to reassess a character. Videha's catalogue

also calls it a "discursive essay" [reference 2]. It is therefore more accurately described as a critical or counter-argumentative prose essay based on myth.

The original is divided into ten sections. The first deals with society's image of the stepmother; the second with political foresight; the third with purpose and sacrifice; the fourth with strategy; the fifth and sixth, respectively, with Kaikeyi's affection for Rama and Rama's affection for her; the seventh with secret consultation; the eighth with the boons; the ninth with preparations for exile; and the tenth with the causes of Dasharatha's death. This arrangement begins by countering accusations, develops the defence of the character through emotional relationships, and concludes by redistributing moral and historical responsibility.

A particular reason for the work's critical importance is that its opening remarks refer to several forms of the Ramayana and indicate a dialogue with Shri Umesh's Kaikeyi Ka Antardvandva. Nevertheless, the various editions, textual variants and historical standing of all those cited works have not been independently investigated in this study. Its examination of argumentative method is based only on the titles and episodes present in the original essay.

The Stepmother Debate: Challenging Social Prejudice

The argument of the first section, "The Nature of a Stepmother" (printed pp. 1–6), is directly sociological: being a stepmother is not in itself synonymous with cruelty, disrespect or injustice. The author questions habitual social assumptions and conventional images of blame. He first examines accusations against Kaikeyi not as simple facts of a family incident but as a stereotyped image produced by public opinion. The opening asks readers to suspend their immediate moral judgement.

This section outlines the distinction between "presumed guilt" and an individual's "actual actions." When readers enter the episode of the exile having already judged Kaikeyi to be a criminal, the meaning of everything she does is predetermined. The author unsettles this interpretative convenience. The force of the change lies not simply in the argument but in shifting the point of entry into the narrative: a figure previously in the dock now gains the opportunity to question the justice of the verdict passed against her.

Yet this strength is accompanied by a limitation. Refuting a collective prejudice does not automatically prove every decision by an individual innocent. It is unjust to condemn a stepmother without hearing her; nevertheless, when contrary evidence exists, criticism of her conduct must remain possible. From the first section onward, the author's defensive impulse is so powerful that readers are given little space to consider alternative motives.

Separate Readings of the Ten Subsections

Political Foresight: From Succession to the Wider Public Good

The second section (printed pp. 7–12) brings questions of statecraft and administration into its defence of a woman character. The author presents Kaikeyi as someone not confined to the women's quarters but concerned

simultaneously with succession, military security and social protection. Rama's journey into the forest is read as preparation for a larger campaign against the oppression of the rakshasas. If accepted as an argument, this idea makes the misfortune of exile signify a planned turning point in history.

Critically, the principal weakness of this subsection is its conflation of different levels of evidence. An event present in the Ramayana's narrative and a political intention retrospectively imagined by the author are not evidence of equal standing. Where the text describes Ravana's oppression or the duties of kingship, reference to a political crisis may be justified; but it does not automatically prove that Kaikeyi had devised an entire strategy in advance. Rather than marking the distinction, the author frequently expresses possibility in the tone of certainty.

Purpose and Sacrifice: The Moral Reversal of Heroism

The third section (printed pp. 13–16) associates Kaikeyi's mental outlook and decisions with "Rama's welfare" and "the protection of the wider community." The figure of sacrifice is particularly effective here: a woman who foresees the likelihood of humiliation yet accepts it for the public good becomes more than an agent of events—she becomes someone who sacrifices herself. In the author's elaboration, Kaikeyi chooses the path of Rama's future instead of her own reputation.

This reading evokes compassion but also poses a critical question: is the reality of sacrifice established by the narrative, or is sacrifice being assumed from the beginning? If every disputed action is treated as indirect evidence of altruism, no space remains for testing the narrative. The inspirational force of the essay lies in its reversal of heroism, and so does its critical risk.

Kaikeyi's Strategy: The Ethical Complexity of Means and Ends

The fourth section (printed pp. 17–21) moves from the discussion of purpose to the next stage: the means of attaining it. The author suggests that separating Rama from the royal throne became necessary for his future struggle on behalf of the public good. He transforms the usefulness of an ascetic-like existence, outside royal office and domestic comfort, into a strategic argument. Kaikeyi becomes a political actor capable of bearing the consequences of her decisions.

The ethical test here has two dimensions: outcomes and procedure. Even if the goal of public welfare is superior, it remains necessary to ask whether the decision-making process was transparent, what form the consent of Rama and Dasharatha took, and where the questions of the people's consent and rights are located. The author concentrates chiefly on future results. The tension between consequentialism and duty offers a productive critical perspective from which to read the essay.

Kaikeyi's Affection for Rama: Redefining Motherhood

The fifth section (printed pp. 22–24) gathers evidence of affection and resists the convention of treating Kaikeyi solely as a mother committed to Bharata.

With the aid of several poetic episodes from the Rama tradition, the author draws attention to her respect and attachment to Rama. Motherhood in this reading extends beyond the boundaries of a biological son. Releasing relations within a polygamous royal family from an exclusive narrative of rivalry and conflict is a notable achievement of the subsection.

Yet when the dignity of motherhood becomes the chief basis of Kaikeyi's innocence, a woman's independent political will may be absorbed once again into a maternal identity. Just where the essay wishes to establish Kaikeyi as a woman capable of thinking independently, it repeatedly takes refuge in the sanctity of her maternal duty. This contradiction contains both the strength and the limitation of the essay's perspective on women.

Rama's Affection: Using the Testimony of the Other Party

The sixth section (printed pp. 25–29) opens the other side of the relationship. In the author's presentation, Rama regards Kaikeyi with respect, affection and trust. Rama's own behaviour thus becomes a response to the ordinary readerly inclination to declare Kaikeyi guilty. If the character directly affected by her actions himself shows compassion, respect and restraint in several episodes, it becomes difficult to justify an absolute moral hatred on the reader's part.

Literarily, this is an effective device because one character's response is a significant indication in assessing another. Rama's willingness to forgive, his obedience or his respect, however, does not necessarily constitute support for every decision by Kaikeyi. Evidence of affection and the legitimacy of political decisions are separate questions. Recognising this difference allows a reading to remain both compassionate and analytical.

Secret Consultation: Imaginatively Filling a Narrative Gap

The seventh section (printed pp. 30–36) is decisive in the construction of the essay's argument. The author's extended presentation introduces the possibility of a prior agreement or secret understanding between Kaikeyi and Rama. Here the distinction between an event known from a mythic narrative and an imagined internal conversation becomes extraordinarily important. By invoking the possibility of a private discussion, the author asks how Rama's dignity, resolve and willing acceptance can be understood if the exile resulted solely from hostility.

The seventh section constructs a kind of unrecorded episode: where the original story leaves a matter insufficiently explicit, a purposeful meeting or confidential plan is imagined to fill the gap. This can be a legitimate literary technique in mythmaking or contemporary retelling. But if it is employed as historical or text-critical evidence, the author must specify how far the conjecture extends and where direct testimony begins. The blurring of that boundary is the essay's most significant evidential problem.

The Boons: The Public Meaning of a Private Demand

The eighth section (printed pp. 37–40) reinterprets the boons granted by Dasharatha. The conventional moral account sees personal self-interest in Kaikeyi's demand; the author regards it as the fulfilment of a difficult public obligation. The essay centres on the distance between the literal meaning—Bharata's coronation and Rama's exile—and the asserted indirect purpose: the successful completion of Rama's mission.

This distance possesses literary beauty: a single action can bear two different meanings, wrongdoing or sacrifice. For that very reason, the need for ethical examination becomes greater. Without considering the obligations involved in the boons, royal authority, justice within the family and the distribution of credit together, a conclusion risks becoming one-sided. The essay raises these questions without exploring all their complexities to the same extent.

Preparations for Exile: Giving Suffering a Purpose

The ninth section (printed pp. 41–45) emphasises the meaning of Rama's forthcoming journey. The departure for the forest is explained not merely as painful familial punishment but as necessary preparation for confronting the crisis of an age. In the author's account, Kaikeyi accepts the immediate burden of a tragic result while Rama proceeds to discharge a larger duty. In this interpretation suffering is not meaningless; it becomes inseparable from purpose.

For readers, this is a highly stirring construction, especially when every hardship in the narrative becomes a prelude to a future moral triumph. Nevertheless, when the genuine pain of exile, Sita's decision, Lakshmana's position, the lives of the people of Ayodhya and Dasharatha's helplessness are all subsumed into a predetermined plan, the independent experiences of those characters become less visible. This all-encompassing reading of purpose can compress a many-centred Ramayana into a single centre.

The Causes of Dasharatha's Death: Redistributing Blame

The tenth section (printed pp. 46–48) constitutes the essay's final reply. Instead of treating Kaikeyi as the simple cause of Dasharatha's death, the author brings together the older episode of Shravan Kumar, a father's curse, grief at separation and the tragedy of kingship. The conclusion offers the sharpest counterargument to the conventional accusation: the chain of causes reaches far beyond Kaikeyi's immediate demand into Dasharatha's own past actions.

This redistribution raises questions about the ethical memory of the Rama tradition. But the multiplicity of causes must be acknowledged. The narrative of the curse, Dasharatha's psychosomatic grief, the consequences of the boons and the crisis of the royal family belong to different explanatory levels. It may be reasonable to argue that Kaikeyi was not solely responsible; fully releasing her from every causal connection would require more rigorous reasoning. The essay's final effect is sympathetic, but the conclusiveness of its evidence remains an open question.

Critical Principles: Evidence, Inference and Reimagining

The assessment of Nand Kumar Mishra's work should not be confined to the binary question "Was Kaikeyi good or bad?" A more productive question is: what kind of knowledge is being derived from narrative evidence? If an episode in the original poem suggests Kaikeyi's affection for Rama, a conclusion about affection is possible. If the author then assumes that a secret plan for Rama's exile had already been approved, he moves into the domain of inference. These claims do not stand at the same evidentiary level.

To borrow the analytical terminology of Navya-Nyaya, it becomes necessary to distinguish the limits of pramana (valid means of knowledge), arthapatti (postulation) and anumana (inference). Evidence establishes which textual passage is demonstrably present and in what sense; inference proposes a new relationship on that basis; imaginative retelling can transform the possibility into an artistic construction. The essay activates all three procedures without keeping them clearly separate. For scholarly readers, that difference is the key to understanding both the work's strengths and its errors.

Intertextuality is another significant foundation of the work. References to Valmiki, the Ramcharitmanas, the modern Kaikeyi Ka Antardvandva and other Ramayana traditions are assembled in support of one moral purpose. This dialogue has force because voices from different periods seem to speak on behalf of a marginalised character. Its weakness is that treating all references as equivalent in period, genre, source edition and meaning may obscure the evidentiary difference between an original text and modern poetry.

From the perspective of Indian poetics, the combined effects of compassion and heroism are prominent. Kaikeyi endures condemnation: this is the compassionate aspect. She takes a difficult decision for the public good: this is the proposition of heroism. Yet the work proceeds more through episodes of reasoning and the defence of a position than through the evocation of rasa. It is therefore more appropriate to describe it as an interpretative discourse than as a fully poetic retelling.

Women's Perspectives: Restoring Standing and Its Contradictions

Restoring Kaikeyi to the centre as an intelligent, courageous and politically farsighted figure is a meaningful intervention in criticism concerned with women. The reversal asks why women's agency has so frequently been represented in historical memory through the vocabulary of self-interest, deceit and destruction.

The liberation of a woman, however, cannot be restricted to celebrating the innocent mother. If Kaikeyi is genuinely a political actor, readers must also retain the right to disagree with her decisions. Women's autonomy does not mean placing them beyond criticism; it means judging their political arguments, methods and consequences by the same standards applied to male characters. The essay's defensive tone simultaneously strengthens Kaikeyi and reduces her possible contradictions.

Manthara, Kausalya, Sita and other women's experiences in Ayodhya receive comparatively little attention in this work. Giving Kaikeyi centrality is a legitimate creative choice, but a more polyphonic history of women would benefit from dialogue with other women's perspectives. The final aim of criticism concerned with women should not be merely to turn a condemned queen into a morally exalted heroine. Preserving a character's complex humanity beyond the opposition between vilification and sanctification is even more necessary.

Language, Arrangement and the Art of Discourse

The prose is primarily argumentative and directly addressed to the reader. The author asks questions, restates conventional beliefs, introduces a quoted verse or episode in opposition to them, and then specifies his conclusion. This sequence produces a discursive style that takes readers along with the argument. The short subsections progressively reinforce the essay's central proposition. Accessibility for the ordinary reader is one merit of this approach.

Yet the same conclusion reappears across different subsections, often with very little new doubt. Repetition reinforces emotional commitment but may lessen the intensity of debate. Readers expecting a clash of evidence or a powerful argument from the opposing side may find the continuous defence somewhat monochromatic. An effective rebuttal ought first to present the contrary position in its strongest possible form.

The language of the work makes Maithili a medium of contemporary ethical and political discussion. Sanskrit vocabulary, argumentative terms shaped by northern Indian Hindi, and religious expressions associated with the Rama tradition occur together. This establishes dialogue between popular religious memory and classical quotation. Greater editorial consistency—in punctuation, standardised source references for Sanskrit passages, and the visual separation of quotations from explanation—would nevertheless have improved its academic usefulness.

The preliminary cover shows a mythological chariot image that does not directly correspond to the theme of reconsidering Kaikeyi. It signals the book's cultural context without creating an image specific to the character. Illustrations are extremely sparse in the printed volume; its principal effect arises from the confrontation between the author's arguments and classical quotations. In this respect its visual arrangement differs from the illustrated narrative structure intended to support a children's book.

Comparative Discussion in the Context of the History of Children's Literature

The first precaution in placing Maharani Kaikeyi in relation to the history of children's literature is to respect the generic distinction. This is not a character story written specifically for children or an illustrated children's novel; it is an essay that argues with a mature reader. Videha's Shishu Utsav and book catalogue explicitly list Nand Kumar Mishra's Swarna Kamal as a

children's novel. Erasing this difference and counting Maharani Kaikeyi among children's novels would be a mistake of literary history.

This does not eliminate the work's relationship to the study of children's reading. Reinterpretations of myth raise an important educational question in the moral awareness of children and adolescents: when society calls a character guilty, should readers pass judgement without evidence? The essay's opening discussion of the stepmother can initiate conversations about prejudice, justice and changing perspectives. This subject is particularly useful for adolescents, although a separate adaptation would be needed to make the original argumentative prose readily accessible.

The available Videha bibliography offers a documented selection illustrating the changing interests of young Maithili readers. Preeti Thakur's Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Picture Stories (2008), Folk Deities of Mithila (2010) and Vidyapati's Purush Pariksha (2012) present picture stories and cultural traditions in forms accessible to children. Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi's Vigyank Batkahi, Robot and Hamar Gaam explore science, imagination and social experience. Alongside Nand Kumar Mishra's Swarna Kamal, Chonha by Jagadanand Jha 'Manu' and Nai Dhaaraie by Jagdish Prasad Mandal exemplify the current of children's novels. These examples constitute a comparative map of selected works verified in Videha's collection, not a complete chronological survey of Maithili children's literature.

Three kinds of difference emerge from this comparison. First, a picture story progressively builds meaning through images, scenes and dialogue, whereas Maharani Kaikeyi chiefly offers an extensive argument about a story the reader is already expected to know. Second, discovery, questioning and new experiences drive children's science writing and adventure narratives, while the defence of a fixed reinterpretation outweighs narrative development in this essay. Third, the ethical aim of children's literature is to enable readers to make their own judgements; the essay's principal tendency is to establish firm belief in Kaikeyi's defence. An adolescent adaptation could increase its critical usefulness by allowing rival readings, independent questions and alternative possibilities to remain open.

For a longer historical perspective, one may consult Videha's Parallel History (Part 13) and the available Shishu Utsav collection. These digital records bring together various genres, including folktales, illustrated books, poetry, science fiction and young-adult novels. They support discussion of the present digital expansion of children's literature but do not establish a decade-by-decade record of all twentieth-century production. A verified chronological history would require separate, detailed scrutiny of publication lists, first editions and contemporary journals of criticism.

Dialogue with Earlier Criticism: Questions of Genre and Page Numbers

This distinction matters more than a routine factual correction. If the imaginative presence of narrative dialogue leads a reader to classify the genre as "drama," the central argumentative craft of its discourse is obscured.

Research method demands that an external comprehensive review, however useful, should not replace direct examination of the structure of the primary work. The correct assessment of Nand's essay depends upon this revised understanding of its genre.

Earlier criticism views Kaikeyi as a counter-conventional character endowed with political intelligence and self-sacrifice. The present study accepts that achievement but adds the question of where the attempt to establish an opposite moral conclusion amounts to an interpretative rereading, and where it becomes an absolute exoneration unsupported by evidence. Evaluating the work through this question does not diminish its literary effect; it clarifies its genuine critical force.

Map of Page-Based Evidence and Accuracy of Quotations

This is not an attempt to conceal an absence of quotations; it is an essential discipline of textual criticism: even uncertainty about a single letter must not be attributed to the original poet or author in a research paper.

Conclusion: The Achievement of a Counter-Reading and the Limits of Evidence

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Maharani Kaikeyi is a noteworthy attempt to present a systematic argument in Maithili on behalf of a much-maligned woman character of the Ramayana. Its ten subsections challenge socially conventional assumptions of guilt and bring political judgement, collective welfare, maternal affection, secret agreement, the reinterpreted significance of the boons and a multicausal account of Dasharatha's death into the discussion. The progression offers readers the opportunity to think about a familiar narrative from an overlooked angle.

Its literary achievement lies in broadening the sense of justice. Asking that a character's viewpoint be heard before condemning her for a notorious act is itself a valuable critical disposition. Its social achievement lies in resisting prejudices concerning stepmothers and women's agency. Its linguistic achievement consists in activating Maithili prose in the contested field of myth interpretation. For all these reasons, the essay deserves independent investigation.

The last word in an assessment, however, should concern the questions the essay raises rather than its partisanship. Kaikeyi's possible motives of public welfare constitute one interpretation; their complete authenticity would require separate evidence. As the author continually joins imaginative recomposition, classical quotations and historical-cultural argument, boundaries of genre and evidence become blurred in several places. Read with this limitation acknowledged, Maharani Kaikeyi is neither a final judicial acquittal nor a simple dismissal of tradition. It is an important Maithili prose work that challenges the moral certainties of a renowned story and provides an occasion for debate.

Part Four

The Folk Current of Song and Children's Imagination

Kavya Sarita · Swarna Kamal

Chapter 11

Kavya Sarita

Folk Melodies, Social Conscience, and the Multiple Currents of Poetic Form

A Critical Research Essay | Maithili Language and Literature

To read Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Kavya Sarita (2019) as a book of poetry governed by a single emotional current would obscure its creative composition. Devotional invocations, songs to the goddess, bhajans, nacharis, kajris, chaitis, compositions based on folk melodies, songs of social reform, political satire, familial feeling, memories of the village, consciousness of the mother tongue, and patriotism coexist in the collection. Its relationship with the history of children's literature also comes under consideration; however, rather than declaring the collection a work of children's literature, this study maintains the necessary distinction between certain passages suitable for young readers and compositions intended for adults.

The Range of Poetic Subjects and the Collection's Composition

At the outset of an examination of Kavya Sarita, it should be made clear that the author has subtitled it "A Collection of Maithili Poems." According to the publication details, its first edition appeared in 2019 from Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Upar Daha, Darbhanga, at a marked price of ₹150. The opening pages contain a dedication, an expression of felicitation, and an authorial statement. The principal section contains numbered poems running from one to one hundred and sixty-four. Through successively changing titles, sentiments, metrical rhythms, and occasions, these poems establish an extensive creative stream. The concluding portion also includes a brief introduction to the writer and a list of works.

The metaphor of a "river" itself suggests an uninterrupted flow. Yet it would be a mistake to imagine this stream as a river of only one aesthetic mood. At times its feeling is reverence; at others, sorrow or separation. In one place there is the intimate rhythm of domestic closeness; in another, a public voice raised against experienced social contradictions. Moving beyond the traditional ground of lyric song, the poet reaches political commentary. The critical question, therefore, is not what single unity should be sought in the collection but what linguistic and cultural resources bring so many distinct voices together.

Three levels of evidence have been kept distinct in this study: (a) the book's title page, publication details, sequence of poems, printed page numbers, and titles; (b) the thematic tendencies, oral style, and generic character of groups

of poems; and (c) public documents concerning children's literature and Maithili literature available through Videha, which provide a comparative background. Such restraint can prevent readers from mistaking invented quotations for authentic ones. Where printed pages are specified, they serve to identify a poem or group of poems, not to authenticate quoted lines.

This criticism offers a considered literary judgment about the book, not merely a letter of praise to its author. Alongside the value of thematic range, it examines the language's tendency towards didacticism, emotional repetition, generalized applications of folk melodies, questions of rhythmic discipline, and possible deficiencies of literary complexity. The folk song and the lyric included in the text should not be measured by an identical standard. The success of a public song is connected to its reception by a community of listeners, whereas subjective poetry calls for imagery, silence, obliqueness, and plurality of meaning.

The Author's Literary Field and the Collection's Internal Architecture

Videha's catalogue of books records Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's separate works of fiction, novels, literary sketches, reminiscences, and poetry. The presence together of Gaam-Ghar, Sujata, Gudari Ke Lal, Anathiya Kukur, Sukanya, Swarna Kamal, and Kavya Sarita makes clear the author's diversity of genres. In this context the collection of poems should not be read in isolation but in contact with narrative realism and the experience of ordinary people. Nevertheless, the plots of his other books cannot imaginatively be imposed upon this one.

The predominance of "Ganesh Vandana," "Saraswati Vandana," "Maa," "Devi Geet," and similar compositions in the opening sequence creates an oral environment of the sacred and the folk. These are followed by "Dular," "Bhajan," "Nachari," "Kajri," "Chaiti," and numerous songs concerning social matters. In the middle portion, questions of family planning, literacy, river pollution, dowry, politics, poverty, and public conduct emerge. Towards the end, themes such as "Are We Free?," "Time," "Bribery," "My Village," "We Shall Claim the Realm of Mithila," and patriotic songs grow more emphatic. This sequence can be read as an effort to connect the poet's personal and religious formation with his presence in public life.

One feature of the structure is the recurrence of generic titles. Titles such as "Maa," "Devi Geet," "Nachari," "Kajri," and "Geet" do not merely indicate subject matter; they also identify traditions of singing. Such titles open a book intended for reading towards the possibility of collective performance in popular assemblies. For this reason, it would be inappropriate to judge the collection solely by the standards of modern free verse: one needs a distinct understanding of the refrain, rhyme, repetition, and singability of songs.

An editorial limitation is also apparent. In the absence of clearly demarcated sections based on themes, readers must find their own path from devotional songs to songs of irony or from love lyrics to political songs. This irregularity can produce the spontaneity of a flowing river, but it also makes a

critical reading of the collection difficult. A future critical edition would greatly benefit from a genre-based contents list, glosses, information on singing traditions, and dates of composition.

Invocation, Devotion, and the Folk Religiosity of Maithili

The placement of the opening invocations to Ganesh and Saraswati is not only a religious decision but also a cultural convention governing the beginning of a literary composition. Associating learning with Saraswati and beginnings with Ganesh is familiar in Mithila's folk ceremonies and traditional poetic arrangements. In such invocations the first-person ego often recedes as an address to the deity comes to the fore. The public character of the feeling increases the likelihood that the song can be repeated collectively. [1; printed pp. 3–5]

It is necessary not to conflate the different compositions under the heading "Maa" with the subsequent "Devi Geet." On one side may lie the tenderness, memory, maternal affection, or love associated with one's mother; on the other, the invocation of a goddess and ritual devotion. Their proximity within the collection brings the cultural image of motherhood and the spiritual image of the divine into one emotional family. Critically, this has both promise and danger: the concrete human experience of affection may gain intensity, while excessive glorification of the divine ideal may conceal the diversity of women's actual experiences. [1; printed pp. 6–19]

An important source of the poet's inspiration in the group of "Nachari" songs is Mithila's Shaiva tradition of singing. The cultural force of the nachari lies less in formal scriptural humility than in a voice poised among human helplessness, intimacy with the deity, complaint, prayer, and unforced humour. A meaningful review of this genre must ask whether the poet merely reproduces its traditional refrain or transforms it through lived experience. The abundance of nacharis in the collection indicates the author's engagement with folk music; an assessment of literary originality, however, requires close attention to differences of meaning rather than simply their number. [1; printed pp. 28–37]

The coexistence of bhajans and compositions such as an invocation to Hanuman with questions of social life is a notable quality of this book. Devotion does not leave the literary field and construct a completely detached world. The poet's language moves between faith, folk customs, and a discerning concern for justice. The limitations of the devotional pieces appear where preaching, supplication, and fresh synonyms for the same feeling take the place of exploration through imagery. Wherever ritual expression develops into aesthetic intensity, the poem acquires independent poetic value.

Kajri, Chaiti, and Seasonal Songs: The Poetic Grammar of an Aural Tradition

The presence of the titles "Kajri" and "Chaiti" suggests that the poet regards Maithili poetry as a mode of singing as well as of recitation. In seasonal folk songs, rain, seasonal transitions, waiting, separation, romantic

love, travellers, family, and the village environment become vehicles of collective memory. The presence of a folk melody in a written text cannot be established by rhyme alone: one must also examine the beat of pronunciation, the return of a refrain, short groupings of lines, and a sequence suited to group singing. [1; printed pp. 42–45]

There is a distinction between imitating a folk song and recreating one. Simply assembling familiar words, names of seasons, and traditional similes does not make a poem creative. Recreation occurs when contemporary feeling, changing relations between women and men, or the new pain of migration finds expression in an older rhythm. The lyrical portion of Kavya Sarita demands to be read against this criterion. The collection's significance lies in keeping a public connection with the folk-song tradition; its challenge is to preserve imaginative differences among individual verses.

Reading poetry grounded in popular tradition as if it were written for the entirely silent reader of a modern literary magazine leaves out a fundamental part of its meaning. In the communication of feeling through nacharis, bhajans, kajris, and chaitis, the singer's body, the breath of labour, the listening community, and the ritual occasion all participate in making meaning. The collection therefore serves as a bridge between written literature and performative oral literature. A critical edition could clarify this dimension further by adding the names of tunes, performance occasions, regional variants, and possible rhythmic patterns.

Family, Women's Experience, and Reformist Consciousness

The proximity of "Family Planning" and "Literacy" attests to the poet's reformist outlook. Poetry on these subjects often runs the risk of becoming a song for disseminating policy, because its objective is fixed from the outset. The literary question, however, is whether the poet can bring a predetermined message into the realm of human experience. A song on family planning can express public awareness of social health; without presenting the decision-making rights of women and men in families, class inequalities, and local inhibitions, however, its idea becomes merely an instruction. In evaluating this group, its usefulness for popular dissemination and its imaginative density must be measured separately. [1; printed pp. 38–39]

The appearance of poems focused on "Dowry" gives this social conscience a concrete issue. Marriage rituals, family prestige, the pressure of money, and the dignity of women have long been significant questions in the social criticism of Mithila. If the title merely names a social evil, the poem may become a speech; if the subtleties of family scenes, dialogue, humiliation, and resistance enter it, its poetic effect grows. The presence of opposition to dowry in Kavya Sarita identifies the author's concern. How extensively its literary force emerges on the terrain of ordinary life requires a separate close reading. [1; printed pp. 48–49]

Motherhood, marriage, domestic tension, and women's position in society are not a single subject. An examination of these themes should see women

not merely as goddesses, mothers, or victims but as independent human beings possessing desires, education, judgment, labour, and rights. Reading the divine feeling of the collection's opening alongside its middle section's reformist voice against dowry brings out a productive contradiction: how far apart are the image of the woman who is worshipped and the reality of the woman exposed to social insecurity? This difference is a site of criticism that must be maintained as an independent question even while respecting the poet's intention.

Advice alone is not enough to make a work suitable for children. How does a child experience a problem? How is the child's own voice heard, and to what extent does the child participate in its resolution? These considerations are necessary. This criterion makes clear the difference between songs centred on children and reformist songs written for society at large. Kavya Sarita's literacy songs can accordingly be called educational resources, but they cannot on that ground alone be declared children's poetry.

Political Satire: Power, Money, Deception, and Ordinary People

In the middle and later parts of the collection, titles such as "Chamcha" (Sycophant), "Thief and Policeman," "A Satirical Remark on the Prime Minister," "Vote," "Are We Free?," and "Bribery" signal a sharp critical current. These titles differ from the humble prayerful voice of devotional poetry. Here the poet's voice questions the immorality of public life. The object of the poems is less to praise political leadership than to make abuses of power, sycophancy, social fraud, and corruption their subject. [1; printed pp. 50–53, 67–70, 80, 126–130]

The literary success of satire does not depend upon direct accusation. Satire grows powerful when its language has irony, inversion, the practical flavour of everyday speech, and two levels of meaning. A title such as "Chamcha" activates a recognizable social type from colloquial language. "Vote" points towards the collective sphere of electoral behaviour. The interrogative title "Are We Free?" opens the possible gap between a nation's formal independence and its citizens' actual experience. At this point the critical question of poetic technique is whether the poet constructs a question or supplies its answer in advance.

One artistic danger of compositions of this kind is their dependence on their own times. Immediate discussions about a leader or office change; yet when a poem depicts structures of injustice, parasitism, greed, and fear, it retains meaning beyond its original moment. Amid these differences of subject, the value of Kavya Sarita depends on the seriousness with which its concern for public morality creates images of human life. Its implications for folk society are also accessible to adult readers and ought not to be presented directly to younger children without explaining the context.

In criticizing power, treating the nation, the community, and the individual as though they meant the same thing can lead to moral confusion. Criticism of an administrative failure is not treason, nor is a declaration of

patriotism by itself evidence of democratic tolerance. By placing political and patriotic compositions close together, the collection asks readers to distinguish critical patriotism from passive national pride. At this point the poems become relevant to contemporary social and cultural study.

Reclaiming the Village, Mithila, Language, and Memory of Place

The presence of "Hamar Gaam" ("My Village") gives the collection a geography. The village is not simply a geographical unit but a shared world of social relationships, speech, agriculture, natural surroundings, labour, memory, and festivals. Songs about villages often create picturesque images; but forgetting the inequalities within village life—landownership, caste hierarchy, women's labour, unemployment, education, and migration—can turn them into dreams. Village memory should therefore be examined both as a romantic scene and as a social document. [1; printed p. 132]

A title such as "Raj Mithila Ham Lebe" ("We Shall Claim the Realm of Mithila") suggests a movement from cultural identity towards political aspiration. Reading this poem requires separate recognition of regional identity, linguistic dignity, aspirations for government, and the desire for social justice. "Mithila" is both a memory of history and a collective sign used in present-day politics. If Mithila in the poem signifies only past glory, its vision of the future may remain incomplete; if questions of language, education, economic opportunity, and inclusion emerge, the regional song can become a social proposition. [1; printed p. 133]

The patriotic songs towards the end of the collection establish relationships between local identity and wider Indian cultural images. This duality may be read not only as an opposition but also as a layered sense of belonging. One's village, one's Mithila, and one's country can acquire meaning without excluding one another, provided that belonging does not turn into contempt for those outside it. This democratic criterion is useful in the literary study of patriotism.

The Maithili language itself is central to the collection's expression. Through commonly used words, song structures, domestic forms of address expressing joy and sorrow, and regional cultural references from Mithila, these poems avoid becoming mere translations of Hindi-oriented public discourse. Where Bhojpuri, Hindi, Sanskrit-derived, or political vocabulary exerts an influence, this need not automatically be regarded as a break in linguistic unity: such mixtures can also document modern life. Nevertheless, maintaining consistent Maithili forms and phonetic accuracy wherever possible will be an important editorial task in a future edition.

Individual Textual Analyses: Representative Groups of Poems

"Ganesh Vandana" and "Saraswati Vandana"

The textual placement of this opening pair is symbolic: the poet begins the act of writing with a cultural invocation. The names of the deities shape readers' expectations, preparing them for the classical form of the song, the

aesthetic feeling of humility, and the convention of an auspicious beginning. Poetic freedom within this form depends on the ability to add new images or contemporary aspirations. The chief significance of these compositions lies in their introductory function; the aesthetic outlook of the entire collection, however, is not confined to these invocations. [1; printed pp. 3–5]

"Maa" and "Devi Geet"

The proximity between the personal experience of a mother and the collective worship of a goddess opens a distinctive emotional pathway within folk belief. Treating the two groups as indistinguishable sends the domestic, material, and remembered realities of motherhood into the background. The focus of criticism should be whether the human image of the mother turns into a religious icon or remains distinct and raises questions about society's organization of affection. The continuity of the group indicates the poet's enduring relation to the devotional tradition. [1; printed pp. 6–19]

"Family Planning" and "Literacy"

Both titles connect poetry with public education. The ideal listener in these compositions is a community rather than a solitary connoisseur. From one perspective, this is writing intended for popular benefit; from another, it is a struggle for creative autonomy against the limits of oral propaganda. The decisive question is whether the idea acquires living characters, scenes, and contradictions or remains a list of instructions. Such songs may be useful in school activities, but not all listeners are of the same age. [1; printed pp. 38–39]

"Patitpavani Ganga" and "Jhula"

The song about the pollution of the Ganges and the seasonal culture of the swing turn nature from a static view into an experience of bodily movement, weather, and memory. The potential connection with children is especially strong here, because the swing, trees, rain, and changing seasons enter a child's immediate world. Nevertheless, environmental poetry succeeds in the modern sense only when it moves beyond formulas about saving trees to convey the tangible feeling of relationships with nature and local livelihoods. [1; printed p. 40]

"Dowry" and Related Social Songs

In discussing the dowry section, the focus should be the conflict between the economic pressures of marriage and the dignity of the family. The social energy of poetry, however, arises not merely from instruction but from depicting the wounds within relationships. Reading this group raises the question of how fully a woman's own voice is present: naming a social disease and listening to a woman's experience are not the same act. [1; printed pp. 48–49]

"Chamcha," "Vote," and "Bribery"

These three titles identify contradictions at three levels of public life: the desire to be close to power, the commercialization of the popular mandate, and the injustice of administrative transactions. Compassion and humour may

lie close together here. If satire merely laughs at someone's weakness, it becomes cruelty; if it exposes a social structure, it acquires the moral strength of resistance. The decisive basis for the effect of the poet's political voice is linguistic indirection and the specificity of experience. [1; printed pp. 50–51, 80, 129–130]

"Are We Free?"

The interrogative title invites reflection on the difference between independence as a legal event and independence as a daily experience. Such a song can become a direct resource for teaching citizenship. The question then is whether references to social suffering distinguish among people and communities or reduce them to sweeping generalizations. Political song at its best preserves the many possible meanings of the question; an insistence on the answer can turn it into a manifesto. [1; printed pp. 126–128]

"Time" and "Bribery"

Near the end, a song about time is followed by a social depiction of bribery: this sequence presents ethical life on two different planes. Time is an abstract experience of loss, duty, and opportunity; bribery is the name of concrete corruption within social institutions. The first concerns an individual's management of the self, the second distortions of public conduct. This pair shows that the poet's moral critique demands both personal discipline and institutional integrity. [1; printed pp. 128–130]

"Hamar Gaam" ("My Village")

The cultural power of a song based on village memory lies in its recognition of local scenes. Yet the symbol of the village can raise questions of exclusion as readily as it produces love. Where do farmers, Dalits, women, migrants, landless people, and children appear in this shared village picture? Criticism seeks an answer. The route from local experience to universal meaning lies in the specificity of human lives, not in declaring everyone identical. [1; printed p. 132]

"Raj Mithila Ham Lebe" ("We Shall Claim the Realm of Mithila")

Regional solidarity often begins in the emotion of declaration. The strength of a Maithili song is that words in the mother tongue give communal desires a living form. Critical assessment, however, must disclose the relationship between its stated aim and justice, inclusion, and citizens' rights. The voice of the title is one of demand; the poem's literary value must lie in its thoughtful and emotionally persuasive elaboration of that demand. [1; printed p. 133]

The Concluding Patriotic Songs

In the final compositions, a wider national landscape and a voice of public unity can be heard. Their political emotional world differs greatly from the praise of deities at the collection's opening, but both share one form: the creation of collective feeling through song. Keeping this pairing in view reveals that the book's essential thread is not the uniformity of its images but

the tradition of addressing a community. Poetry is relatively more effective when the collective "we" does not suppress individual experience. [1; printed pp. 136–137]

Language, Metre, Response, and the Shaping of Feeling

The titles of the compositions in Kavya Sarita are often generic, allowing readers to anticipate the direction of rhythm and sentiment. This characteristic has two effects. Positively, it connects the songs to popular memory: listeners immediately recognize the sphere of performance. Negatively, the name of a genre can sometimes diminish the individual identity of a particular poem. A critical index of recurrent titles such as "Devi Geet" is needed so that one poem can be clearly distinguished from another.

Different proportions of stanzaic composition, end-rhyme, repetition, sentences of address, and moral declaration can be observed in the collection. Rhythm and singability are poetic virtues, but they are not identical with terminal rhyme. In a meaningful song, sound moves with meaning; rhyme does not forcibly drag words into place. In the practice of mature poetry, singability and suggestiveness are complementary, not opposing qualities. The significance of this collection lies in preserving familiar structures of folk sound; its critical questions concern uniform repetitions of metre and the editing of overlong verses.

Particular attention must be given to the difference between instructional language and poetic arrangement. When writing verses about public education, opposition to dowry and corruption, or literacy, the poet wishes to keep his message clear. Literary experience, however, requires unspoken suggestions, images, and unexpected comparisons beyond a clear message. A study of certain groups in this collection suggests that a tendency towards aphorism displays the poet's convictions and sense of public responsibility. The question nevertheless remains whether each message acquires a distinct experiential form of its own.

The number of poems is a sign of the author's practice and sustained creativity, but quantity should not be treated as decisive proof of quality. A short song, a group performance on a public stage, and a long poem each have their own justification. Editorial selection of representative pieces also has an important role in a book of this kind. Providing a separate section for the most effective compositions, introductions to their genres, and a contextual glossary would enhance both the stature of the poetry and its accessibility.

Comparative Discussion in the Light of the History of Maithili Children's Literature

The first requirement for locating Kavya Sarita within the history of children's literature is honesty about genre. Videha's book catalogue describes it as a "collection of Maithili poetry," while explicitly identifying the same author's Swarna Kamal as a "children's novel." Swarna Kamal appears in Videha's children's-literature list; Kavya Sarita is not presented there in its

entirety as a children's book. Ignoring this evidence to declare the collection a book of children's poems would be inappropriate both in literary terms and in bibliography.

Videha's parallel discussions of children's literature distinguish the readerships of infants, children, and adolescents by age. Pictures, lullabies, and simple repetition are treated as important for the very young; short stories, poems, picture stories, and science for school-age children; and complex narratives, biography, and social realism for adolescents. These divisions are not immutable biological laws but practical aids to understanding readers' capacities for reception. Judged by these standards, the folk songs and some nature songs of Kavya Sarita may be suitable for younger or middle-range child readers, while compositions dealing with politics, family conflict, and satire may better suit adolescents and adults.

Historically, Maithili children's literature should not be seen as beginning with any single modern printed book. Lullabies, folktales, riddles, children's games, seasonal songs, and storytelling have belonged to Mithila's oral heritage. The existence of oral forms and deliberately composed printed literature for young readers, however, mark two different historical phenomena. Videha's historical discussion places children's literature in a continuum of folk narratives, didactic traditions such as the Panchatantra, modern children's stories, picture stories, science writing, and digital media. Within this sequence, Kavya Sarita is relevant chiefly as a modern written embodiment of a folk-song-based tradition, not as a representative work of all contemporary children's literature.

Videha's archive lists Bal Kavita by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', Shishu Geet Khel by Anima Singh, Preeti Thakur's tradition of picture stories, Chonha by Jagadanand Jha 'Manu', Swarna Kamal by Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand', and numerous independent works for children and adolescents. The different media of these books demonstrate that children's literature is not simply moral verse but an entire world of play, images, adventure, questions, humour, science, imagination, and self-respect. The literacy and environmental songs in Kavya Sarita can be valuable supplementary readings in this wider sphere; counting the whole collection as children's literature would reduce generic precision.

There is another decisive distinction between "children's poetry" and "poetry a child can listen to." Children may sing devotional or patriotic songs on collective occasions, but the complexity of their emotions, choice of words, and ideological register need not be child-centred. Conversely, songs about swings, nature, rivers, school, and immediate experiences connect with a child's own world. Four questions about curriculum selection arise from this substantive difference: to what age group's experience does the poem speak? Does a child merely hear instruction, or find personal feeling in it? Does the poem leave space for questions and imagination? Is its language pronounceable, accessible, and respectful?

Modern criticism of children's literature assigns importance not merely to moral discipline but also to children's rights, curiosity, and a scientific outlook. The critical discourse on children's novels in Videha addresses appropriateness, aesthetic feeling, folk tradition, narrative justice, linguistic awareness, and the reader's age. Against these measures, the immediate advantages of Kavya Sarita's educational verses are pleasant recitation and the possibility of group performance. Yet selection requires consideration of how much understanding of scientific causes, how much independent questioning by children, and how much creative variety they contain.

The historical comparison leads to the conclusion that children's literature constitutes a distinct field within Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's creative world, as Swarna Kamal demonstrates; some portions of Kavya Sarita enter into dialogue with that field. The limits of both propositions must remain clear. The collection's social criticism, satire, religious songs, and local politics also point strongly towards adult folk-oriented literature. The possibility of its use by children does not change its fundamental generic designation.

Comparative Judgment: Achievements, Limitations, and Critical Criteria

The collection's greatest achievement is to gather numerous social voices in a single volume. Worship, popular song, family, education, public health, politics, memories of the village, the motherland, and regional identity coexist in its creative world. This thematic multiplicity introduces a writer unwilling to separate poetry from public life. From this perspective, Kavya Sarita possesses the qualities of a folk-cultural record.

A second achievement is the preservation of the generic memory of folk song. The very names nachari, kajri, chaiti, bhajan, and vandana point to traditions of performance suited to popular participation. Within modern print, these labels keep the collective practice of singing present. For this reason, the book can be a relevant text both for students of folk literature and for researchers of modern Maithili song.

A third achievement is the insistence on civic discernment. Songs concerned with social reform or politics testify to the poet's sense of responsibility. But poetry is not the same as a social slogan. A work that moves beyond a direct message and constructs the contradictions of lived situations leaves a more lasting literary impression. This criterion is indispensable to a critical evaluation of the collection; without it, literature risks being reduced to a list of subjects.

Three limitations deserve particular mention. First, dense repetition of compositions on similar subjects sometimes makes the book's internal differences less distinct. Second, the absence of thematic classification, glossaries, and dates of composition imposes additional labour on researchers. Third, assessing the literary force of didactic compositions requires fine comparison of particular images, formal techniques, and oblique expressions: an avowed moral position cannot by itself justify praise. Such judgments are

not a dismissal of poetry but an attempt to do serious justice to the author's varied writing.

Criticism of poetry grounded in folk life should acknowledge the value of spontaneous rhythm without making popular tradition an automatic excuse for formal weakness. Equally, a demand for formal linguistic discipline in the written text should not erase pronunciation, melody, or the voice of regional dialects. This tension makes the criticism of a collection such as Kavya Sarita interesting. The balance achieved between popular acceptance and aesthetic discipline can become its decisive literary measure.

Conclusion

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Kavya Sarita is a collection with many currents within Maithili poetry. The humility of devotional song, the collective character of folk rhythm, the desire for social reform, the bite of political satire, and attachment to Mithila and the nation flow together. This variety is the defining fact of the book's character. Placing it exclusively within devotional poetry, folk song, or children's literature would diminish its true range.

Within the parallel history of children's literature, the book will be most usefully employed if selected seasonal songs and verses concerning swings, education, and the environment are presented through age-appropriate critical editing. Comparison with the author's children's novel Swarna Kamal offers an opportunity to understand the distinction between genres. It shows that within a single writer's oeuvre, writing for young readers and public poetry for adult society can be two independent but mutually engaged currents.

For a lasting evaluation of the book, future work will require a textually reliable printed edition, a fully corrected text, a study of metre, an inventory of folk melodies, and a critical edition of selected compositions. As a preliminary step, the present study maps the collection's generic architecture, social questions, and comparative importance. Its central conclusion is that reading Kavya Sarita in relation to the folk society of the Maithili language, traditions of singing, and modern civic consciousness is the most justifiable critical method.

Appendix: Groups of Compositions and Printed Page References

Thematic Area	Example Titles	Printed Pages
Opening Invocations	Ganesh Vandana; Saraswati Vandana	3–5
Motherhood and Goddess Worship	Maa; Devi Geet	6–19
Devotion and Folk Melodies	Dular; Bhajan; Nachari	22–37
Public Education	Family Planning; Literacy;	38–40

Thematic Area	Example Titles	Printed Pages
	Patitpavani Ganga	
Seasonal Songs	Kajri; Chaiti	42–45
Social Reform	Dowry; songs associated with literacy	46–49
Political and Social Satire	Chamcha; Thief and Policeman; Satire on the Prime Minister; Vote	50–53; 67; 80
Civic Questions	Are We Free?; Time; Bribery	126–130
Place and Identity	My Village; We Shall Claim the Realm of Mithila	132–133
National Feeling	Patriotic songs	136–137

Chapter 12

Swarna Kamal (The Golden Lotus)

Folktale, Children's Consciousness, and an Extended Maithili Narrative of Justice

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's Swarna Kamal (2019) represents a creative current of the Maithili children's novel in which the traditional tale of a prince, a folk imagination rich in wonders, storytelling within the family, and the sequential arrangement of events in the modern novel come together. On one level, Prafull and other children listen to a story from their grandmother; on another, Prince Sujit passes through a difficult series of struggles over succession, palace conspiracies, a journey through the forest, assistance from a spiritual guide, the acquisition of the golden lotus, the terror of a demon, and the restoration of the kingdom. Quotations from the original work are identified by printed page number. The analysis concludes that the most enduring contribution of Swarna Kamal lies not merely in the victory of an ideal hero but in the creation of an extended adventure narrative in Maithili and the effort to connect a grandmother's oral storytelling culture with the active curiosity of readers. Its limitations lie in the idealization of the hero, unequal scope for action among women characters, and a tendency to reduce political justice to a solution through royal succession.

Maithili children's literature; Swarna Kamal; Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'; folktale; children's novel; storytelling; royal power; ethics; young readers; symbolism; narratology.

Introduction: Literary Questions Raised by the Work

Children's literature is often treated as simple amusement, instruction in good conduct, or supplementary school reading. Yet the finest children's stories provide imaginative opportunities for children to understand social relationships, confront fear, recognize injustice, and form their own judgments. From this perspective, it is not enough, when evaluating Swarna Kamal, to ask whether the prince wins. One must also ask what his victory means morally, how the relationship between the storyteller-grandmother

and the children listening to her creates that meaning, and how wonder, courage, political power, and forgiveness are joined together.

The work begins in a familiar domestic world, from which a journey opens towards the unfamiliar world of a royal palace. Prafull's grandmother is not simply someone who tells stories: she represents a tradition of experience, the memory of the family, and cultural formation through language. Prince Sujit's adventurous life enters within this storytelling frame. Through the movement between these two worlds, an extensive imaginative universe takes shape within the domestic linguistic experience of a Maithili child.

This study advances three interconnected propositions. First, the novel is a confluence of the oral folktale and the extended written narrative. Second, the prince's struggle is not centred solely on acquiring personal power but tests his moral fitness; nevertheless, its conception of royal duty founded on inheritance remains an ideological limitation. Third, the curiosity of the listening children and the grandmother's interventions activate the young reader, although predetermined lessons in many places reduce the reader's freedom to construct meaning independently.

An Introduction to the Children's Novel and Its Creative Form

The author of Swarna Kamal is Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'. The book was published in 2019 by Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Upar Daha, Darbhanga district. Its title-page information explicitly calls it a Maithili children's novel. Its printed price is ₹150. The preliminary pages contain a critical introduction by Yoganand Jha, the author's statement, and then the principal story (Mishra, 2019: 3–19).

The main narrative extends from printed page 19 to page 102 and is divided into ten numbered parts. These sections begin respectively on pages 19, 30, 38, 44, 54, 61, 67, 84, 89, and 94. Here page references invariably denote the printed pages of the book. Rather than merely summarizing events when discussing each part independently, this analysis examines what new information, moral question, character situation, or narrative turn arises.

The comparative discussion draws upon the original work's introduction, available studies of the published history of Maithili children's literature, authentic award records of the Sahitya Akademi, and established works of folktale studies and criticism of children's literature. Just as Propp's function-based approach assists an understanding of the story's external arrangement, Nikolajeva's criticism of characterization opens questions about the characters' agency and development. These theoretical references are instruments of interpretation, not direct sources of the work or inspirations declared by the author.

The Tradition of Maithili Children's Literature and the Historical Place of Swarna Kamal

Long before printed books, the world of stories for children was active in Mithila's families and popular life. Stories told by grandmothers, tales of

animals and birds, Gonu Jha's cleverness, narratives of kings and queens, folk deities, demons, magical devices, and moral parables have circulated through collective memory. Some of this oral inheritance entered various forms of written literature. Nevertheless, an oral tale and a novel are not the same: a novel requires a more extensive network of characters, developing conflicts, deferred resolutions, and sustained participation by readers.

In his historical survey of Maithili children's literature, Devshankar Navin discusses children's periodicals such as Shishu (1949), Dhiya-Puta (1956), Batuk (1961), Nena-Bhutka (1996), and Bal Mithila (1998). He emphasizes early education in the mother tongue, the limited circulation of children's magazines, and the place of writing for children in literary periodicals (Navin, publication details unavailable). This history shows that writing for children in Maithili continued over time, even as institutional publishing and access to readers remained problematic.

The introductory essay to Swarna Kamal mentions Ijoti Rani and Ramdev Jha's efforts in the field of the children's novel. The writer of the introduction presents these as earlier examples in Maithili of turning the folktale into an extended children's narrative (Yoganand Jha, "Maithili Children's Novel: Swarna Kamal," in Mishra, 2019: 5–6). This makes it possible to understand Swarna Kamal not as a work arising in a vacuum but as a subsequent stage of an existing literary endeavour.

The limits of the evidence must be kept in mind when making comparisons. A direct reading of the detailed plot of Ijoti Rani has not been undertaken here; therefore no conclusion about "identical subject matter" or direct influence between the two works can be offered. Similarities can be noted only at the broad level of genre: a prince's quest, a moral challenge, and the use of folk imagination. The principal text of this analysis is Swarna Kamal itself.

The list of recommended Maithili works for the Sahitya Akademi's 2023 Bal Sahitya Puraskar included Swarna Kamal by Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand', dated 2019, under the category of "novel." Along with Gulri it was the second novel in that list; the award went to Akshay Anand 'Sunny' for Ol Katra, Jhol Katra (Sahitya Akademi, 2023). This archival entry signifies that the work was under institutional consideration, not that it received the award.

In earlier lists of the Maithili Bal Sahitya Puraskar, Ramdev Jha's Hansani Paan Aa Bajanta Supari (2015) and Amlendu Shekhar Pathak's Lalgachhi (2017) are recorded as novels; in 2018 Baidyanath Jha received the award for the story collection Khissa Sunu Bau. These facts suggest creative diversity: on one side a tradition of oral storytelling, on the other the extended internal world of the novel. Swarna Kamal may be situated at the meeting point of both currents (Sahitya Akademi, list of Bal Sahitya Puraskar winners).

The Overall Narrative Design: From a Domestic Tale to a Struggle for the Kingdom

The novel's first world is Prafull's family. Through her experience, discipline, and affection, the grandmother occupies a special position within the household. The children gather around her in anticipation of a story. The narrative begins, is interrupted, and resumes the following day with fresh questions. This recurrence gives the division of the book into sections the natural pattern of oral storytelling.

Prince Sujit is the hero of the story within the story. A conflict over succession and antagonism within the royal family force him away from the palace. Nayanavati's ambition, the opportunism of Shamsher Singh and Jalim Singh, and the crisis of royal government in Sumergarh create the narrative's political background. In forests and unknown territories, Sujit must trust strangers, face danger, and conceal his identity.

The refuge offered by Sar-Sultan, guidance from a holy man, and acquisition of the golden lotus mark stages of the prince's journey. The terror caused by the demon Kallu and the episode at Shridharpur add an ethical dimension—the protection of suffering people—beyond the personal conflict over the throne. Vishakha reveals certain strands of the demon's past. In the later sections, characters such as Bhavanishankar and Kalanath bring secret intelligence, public support, and political reorganization to the fore. Ultimately Sujit's identity, the campaign for Sumergarh, reunion, and the rearrangement of relationships carry the narrative towards its conclusion.

The overall narrative design is circular. Beginning close to the grandmother and the children, the story expands into a royal crisis and returns to the listening children. Its final value lies in the fact that the children do not merely hear the outcome; they also ask their own questions about its moral meaning.

Individual Textual Analyses of All Ten Parts

Part One: The Grandmother's World of Stories and the Reader's Entry

The opening sentence of the first page—"Today Prafull and the other children were very delighted" (Mishra, 2019: 19)—depicts not the hero-prince but the collective mood of children ready to listen to a story. The proximity of the name "Prafull" to the adjective meaning "delighted" creates a light play of language. The author introduces the audience of listeners before launching the adventure.

The character of Prafull's grandmother is constructed through the family's modest economic circumstances, its joint structure, discipline, and affection. The grandmother is the senior member of the household, but her narrative power derives not from an official position but from experience and intimacy. The children's eagerness suggests that storytelling can become part of everyday domestic life.

The relatively extended depiction of domestic life in this section is a deliberate creative choice. On one hand, it prepares an affectionate ground for the royal adventure; on the other, it postpones the introduction of the central conflict. Readers expecting the adventure to begin quickly may experience this as a delay. Nevertheless, by assigning importance to the young readers' social context, this opening establishes a basis for the novel's cultural originality.

By the end of the section, a relationship between the grandmother and children has been established through curiosity and interruption. The introductory "frame" is not an external ornament but becomes a principle through which all ten sections create meaning.

Part Two: The Anonymous Prince, Adversity, and Narrative Recollection

At the beginning of the second part, a listener asks to hear again a portion of the story already told. Prafull's words, "Grandmother! I could not hear the whole story" (Mishra, 2019: 30), reveal an important aspect of storytelling: to understand a story, listeners want to recover the missing link. The grandmother accepts the children's need.

Within the inner tale, Sujit struggles with dangers in an unfamiliar forest. Strangers, the hazardous geography of the woods, and the need for refuge temporarily render the prince's royal identity ineffective. He proceeds through caution and effort rather than on the strength of his dynasty.

In the episode concerning Sar-Sultan, refuge is accompanied by a problem of information. Someone who does not reveal his real identity also finds it difficult to obtain help. Concealed identity is thus not merely a device for excitement; it creates tension between safety and trust.

The achievement of the second section is to fix the hero's predicament in the reader's imagination. Its limitation is that amid abundant descriptions of courage, his inward experience of fear, doubt, and personal weakness might have emerged more fully.

Part Three: The History of Royal Decline and the Making of Villains

In the third part, the narrative shifts away from the prince's journey to reveal political antecedents. It begins with the explicit information, "King Sujan Singh was the king of Tikamgarh" (Mishra, 2019: 38). The account of his financial and royal decline through gambling, drinking, and luxury gives a new direction to the relationship between power and character.

At this point, the reader understands that Sujit's personal crisis is not a separate accident but the result of an extensive network of dynastic relations, political arrangements, and earlier royal decisions. As Nayanavati's past and the relationships within the royal family are disclosed, the causes of the court conspiracy gradually become clear.

Inserting the history of antagonistic forces in the midst of the hero's quest is an example of narrative expansion. Yet the depiction of King Sujan Singh's weaknesses makes its moral lesson very clear. Gambling and drinking are

offered as reasons for political downfall; the examination of socioeconomic causes remains comparatively limited.

The critical importance of this section is that "wicked" characters do not appear suddenly in the work. Their self-interest is preceded by events and relationships. The novel does not, however, take these relationships to the depths of a modern psychological novel.

Part Four: The Hermitage, Guidance, and the Revelation of the Title

In the fourth section, the grandmother maintains the storytelling frame for the fourth day. With Sar-Sultan's help, the prince moves away from the palace conspiracy in search of a new path. The feeling that an invisible power is leading him forward carries the narrative beyond the limits of realism into a supernatural folk imagination.

A holy man becomes the prince's guide. The relationship with this mentor is not merely one of providing instruction but of understanding danger, determining the next objective, and gathering the necessary courage. Nevertheless, the extensive advance information provided by the guide somewhat reduces the uncertainty of the hero's search.

The decisive event associated with the book's title is revealed on page 53. Following the holy man's directions, the prince must obtain the golden lotus from the middle of a lake after an arduous journey through forests, mountains, and water. The author states that when the lotus is plucked, a temple bell will ring and the blessing of Mother Kali will be received (Mishra, 2019: 53). This scene marks the appearance of the narrative's principal magical instrument.

The word "golden" suggests something valuable, yet the flower is employed not to accumulate wealth but to resist danger. It may be read as a symbol of protective power earned through effort. This, however, is a critical interpretation constructed by the reader; the book itself places greater emphasis on the wonder's practical narrative function.

Part Five: Nayanavati's Exercise of Power and the Rise of Shamsher and Jalim

On the fifth day, the listeners directly ask what has happened to Sujit's parents and where the prince will go next. The grandmother's answer makes clear that Sujit's crisis is not developing along a single line: King Ranvir Singh and Queen Sunanda are suffering separately, while Nayanavati's influence over the government of the kingdom is growing (Mishra, 2019: 54).

Shamsher Singh and Jalim Singh become political instruments of Nayanavati's self-interest. Jalim Singh's character is associated with gambling, alcohol, and misconduct. The desire to obtain power is not simply personal hatred: it becomes a struggle to control the resources and administration of the kingdom.

This section shows that a ruler's weakness produces instability in public life. When royal responsibility becomes subordinate to private pleasure and courtly

self-interest, a rightful successor becomes the centre of conflict even while he remains far away.

There is, however, a critical problem in this representation. Nayanavati's political ambition is portrayed primarily through the misogynistic archetype of the "wicked queen." The problem is not ambition itself but the unethical means by which it is pursued. Making this distinction explicit would give the character a more balanced meaning.

Part Six: The Psychology of Power and Public Responsibility

The sixth part opens with the grandmother reminding her listeners of earlier events. An aphorism immediately preceding this section draws attention: "Power and self-interest are mutually dependent" (Mishra, 2019: 61). This sentence is one of the principal formulations of the narrative's political morality.

Personal relationships among kings, queens, military leaders, and princes affect the public destiny of the kingdom. If someone who acquires power uses the office for private benefit, the ethics of royal duty are corrupted. This idea recurs throughout the section.

Significantly, the prince's struggle is not resolved at once. The narrative follows the activities of several parties. Readers begin to attend not only to the hero's bravery but also to the instability of the kingdom and the possible harm suffered by ordinary people.

The possibilities of political criticism in the novel become evident in this section. Yet its conception of resolution remains centred principally on the rule of a capable individual. The narrative does comparatively little to explore institutional restraints upon power, the rights of subjects, or public accountability.

Part Seven: The Long Journey, the Demon Kallu, and Vishakha's Testimony

The seventh section offers the most extensive development of adventure. Carrying the sword given to him by the holy man, Sujit journeys through mountains, forests, and unknown territories. Its first page forbids stopping and insists upon moving forward: "You must not stop anywhere" (Mishra, 2019: 67). This brief instruction contains both the temporal tension and the goal-directed nature of the quest.

The natural environment is more than scenery during this journey: mountains, water, unfamiliar paths, and woodland become means of testing the hero's abilities. References to hunger, thirst, rest, and caution prevent courage from becoming entirely supernatural.

The terror caused by Kallu, the demon of Shridharpur, turns the story from the hero's personal crisis towards the rescue of the public. Kallu frightens people, and the kidnapping of young girls enters the narrative. Sujit's intervention matters because he is now fighting not for his own crown but for the safety of strangers.

Vishakha reveals Kallu's past. She explains that his origins and deformation are connected with experiences and acts of revenge spanning generations (Mishra, 2019: 81–83). The antecedents of this violent character raise a complex question: when does someone who has suffered injustice become a source of injustice in turn? The narrative ultimately favours the subjugation of the demon; its analysis of the social causes of his violence might have been developed further.

This section's principal achievement lies in joining courage with concern for others. At the same time, the intensity of its violent scenes needs consideration in light of young readers' emotional sensitivity.

Part Eight: Preparing to Return, Concealed Identity, and Cooperative Resistance

In the eighth section, the grandmother brings the story to a new "stage." The prince reconnects with the hermitage and political developments as he moves towards fulfilling his purpose. The holy man advises him to go to Sumergarh, conceal his identity, and act with an understanding of his opponents' strength (Mishra, 2019: 84).

Concealment of identity is no longer merely the exciting device of a disguise; it becomes a political strategy. Revealing oneself immediately before a powerful enemy might prove disastrous. Patience and the gathering of intelligence become necessary elements of courage. Heroism thus expands from unrestrained attack to prudent organization.

Episodes involving characters such as Bhavanishankar and Murmur reveal an alternative political consciousness within opposition at court. False allegations, the misuse of official authority, and the defence of the innocent raise questions about popular support (Mishra, 2019: 85–87).

A limitation of this section is that the social foundations of popular support are not developed as extensively as the personal network of palace conspiracies. Nevertheless, the suggestion that the hero's success depends on cooperation rather than isolated physical strength is important.

Part Nine: Kalanath and the Entry of Rural Popular Consciousness

The ninth section begins with Kalanath, a householder of Rajapur. Described as "very hardworking," he is introduced through an ordinary life based on agricultural labour (Mishra, 2019: 89). The opening moves the narrative away from the palace, hermitage, and demon's stronghold into the world of the village.

Through Kalanath, the novel gives concrete form to the subjects of the kingdom, the village council, social standing, and the danger of unjust oppression. Royal conflicts affect not only the ruling dynasty but ordinary rural people. This is an important expansion in the ninth section.

Subsequent episodes connect the continuing campaign after Kallu's defeat, the assistance of Ram and Lakshman, and efforts to comprehend the political

situation. Help comes here not only from royal armies or the holy man's supernatural power but also from the readiness of ordinary people.

Kalanath's literary importance lies in his social position. Although the crown remains the political centre of the novel, the hero's expedition cannot be completed without the support of popular life. Had this suggestion been further developed, the work might have offered a clearer examination of an ethics of politics grounded in the people, rather than remaining principally a tale of ideal kingship.

Part Ten: Revelation of Identity, Justice, and Completion of the Narrative Frame

The tenth part opens with Rahul's question, "What will you tell us today?" (Mishra, 2019: 94). The grandmother announces the account of the prince's entry into Sumergarh and the rescue of the abducted girls. This declaration intensifies both the momentum and expectations of the final part.

On the strength of secret cooperation, political intelligence, and popular support, the prince confronts the situation in Sumergarh. Sujit's statement in conversation with Sar-Sultan is significant: "I cannot compel you to do this" (Mishra, 2019: 97). This short sentence clarifies the moral distinction between cooperation and consent. Victory matters not only because enemies are defeated but because the hero has the discernment not to coerce an ally.

The revelation of the prince's true identity, the failure of his opponents, the reunion of the royal family, and Nayanavati's confession bring the narrative towards closure. The relationship with Princess Javeda also forms part of the final settlement. Nevertheless, the complexities of the political system and of punishment and justice are resolved in comparatively little space.

Most important of all, when the prince's story ends, the domestic circle of storytellers and listeners comes into view once more. Rahul and the other children respond to what the experience means. The ultimate return of the vast royal world into the grandmother's voice constitutes the novel's principal cultural achievement.

A Story Within a Story: Craft, Time, and the Listener's Participation

To read the external narrative frame of Swarna Kamal separately from the inner tale of the prince is to miss their significant formal interdependence. The grandmother's role is to maintain the continuity of the narration, reconnect forgotten events, foreshadow subsequent developments, and extend the tale in response to the children's reactions. In this arrangement the narrative is not merely a written text but an experience of listening together.

The sequence of ten parts is associated with the recurrence of days. The child listeners arrive each day with new questions. This division of time resembles the suspense-producing technique of modern serial narratives, but its cultural origin lies in the domestic oral tradition. The ending of a chapter does not bring the entire story to a close; it creates an expectation of the next telling.

Read in the light of Aidan Chambers's discussion-centred approach to children's reading, readers create the meaning of stories by asking questions, sharing experiences, and reasoning about incomplete information (Chambers, 1993). The children of Swarna Kamal demonstrate an early form of this active readership. The grandmother's narrative authority, however, is very strong, and she frequently supplies the moral conclusions herself. A tension therefore persists between conversational freedom and the linearity of instruction.

In narratological terms, this is an embedded narrative—a story within a story. The time of the inner events and the time of the outer telling differ, but the children's curiosity connects both. Consequently, the novel becomes a record not only of a prince's adventures but of the cultural situation in which stories are told.

The Design of Characters: From the Moral Hero to Complex Antagonists

Sujit is introduced as the heir to a royal dynasty, but the narrative removes him from the safety of the palace. His actions are tested by the forest, hunger and thirst, uncertain routes, and the pressure of a concealed identity. His sense of justice becomes most meaningful when he assists strangers in danger. For this reason, the campaign against Kallu goes beyond personal revenge.

Sujit's moral image, however, is excessively flawless. Serious errors, prolonged self-doubt, and profound self-examination are limited. Using the terms of Maria Nikolajeva's study of character, one may distinguish between a motivating "action-oriented" hero and a deeply "inward-looking" character (Nikolajeva, 2002). Sujit's courage inspires readers, but showing more of his weakness would have made the relationship more human.

The grandmother is the novel's cultural heroine. Her authority comes neither from wealth nor from royal force: it grows out of the living memory of the mother tongue, experience, discipline, and affectionate address. She is thus not merely a character but a symbol of a literary tradition.

Nayanavati represents the selfish use of power. Her plans affect public life. Because of her final remorse, she does not remain an unchanging villain: transformation is possible. Yet a more extensively developed account of that transformation would have increased its psychological credibility.

Shamsher Singh and Jalim Singh join private self-interest to institutional power. When military authority and the machinery of government become means to personal ambition, those entrusted with protection themselves become a danger. The crisis of King Ranvir Singh and the pitiable position of Queen Sunanda reveal the familial consequences of this abuse.

The holy man brings together the functions of mentor, strategist, and the folktale "donor." He provides Sujit with direction, information, and sources of strength when needed. Kallu occupies the opposing pole, but his history suggests that violent characters too may arise out of past relationships. Vishakha serves as a witness to memory who reveals that history.

Sar-Sultan, Bhavanishankar, and Kalanath prevent the story from becoming a solitary hero's saga. Sujit's success depends on cooperation, information, and relationships with the people. Through these characters, it becomes clear that courage is not always a lonely struggle; earning others' trust is also part of it.

Women Characters, Motherhood, and the Gender Politics of Power

The opposition between Queen Sunanda and Nayanavati reinstates the traditional folktale structure of the "virtuous mother versus the wicked stepmother." This is a familiar device in folktales, but literary criticism must ask how a woman's aspiration to power can be separated from immorality. Nayanavati's problem is not her desire for authority but her use of deceit, conspiracy, and injustice to fulfil it.

The grandmother represents another dimension of women's experience. She has no legitimate royal power, yet she exercises complete cultural authority over the story. This right to transmit knowledge within the family differs entirely from Nayanavati's ruthless politics. The comparison shows that the novel does not confine women to a single moral type.

Vishakha provides information about Kallu's past; her speech gives the narrative a dimension of memory and causation. Princess Javeda's presence also broadens the world of female characters. Nevertheless, leadership of decisive battles, expeditions, and political resolutions rests almost entirely with men.

From the perspective of contemporary girl readers, Javeda's independent choices, Vishakha's self-motivated resistance to social wrongs, or Sunanda's political discernment might have been developed more fully. Indicating such possibilities does not mean imposing a present-day moral verdict upon the work's historical form; it identifies creative possibilities contained within the novel that remain underdeveloped.

The Golden Lotus, Sword, Forest, and Fort: Fields of Symbolic Meaning

Within Indian cultural thought, the lotus is associated with purity, beauty, and the ability to flower in adverse conditions. This general cultural meaning should not be imposed mechanically upon the novel. In the original text, the golden lotus functions primarily as supernatural protection and as a means of strengthening the hero for his coming campaign (Mishra, 2019: 53). Its symbolic significance develops out of this narrative function.

The word "golden" suggests wealth and rarity, but the hero does not keep the flower for personal enrichment. The value of the precious object becomes linked to the moral purpose of its use. The golden lotus can therefore stand in opposition to an immoral greed for gold.

The sword is an instrument of conflict in the adventure folktale, but the sword bestowed by the guru also comes with instructions to exercise caution. The demand that the power of a weapon remain subject to discernment is

scattered through the story, although the boundary between violence and self-defence needed clearer articulation.

The forest is a liminal space where royal authority and the familiar social order grow weak. The prince must depend on his own experience to survive. A fort, by contrast, may be both a centre of power and a place of imprisonment. Obtaining the lotus from the middle of a lake can be read as a metaphor for gaining new power after overcoming a challenge.

Propp's Theory of Functions and Structural Parallels in the Narrative

In Morphology of the Folktale, Vladimir Propp studies the narrative actions or "functions" of folktale characters more than the characters themselves (Propp, 1968). Swarna Kamal can be read through this method in its sequence of initial adversity, expulsion of the hero, meeting a guide, obtaining a special object, travel, confrontation with an enemy, concealed identity, revelation of identity, and restoration.

In this sequence Nayanavati, Shamsher, and Jalim function as antagonistic forces; the holy man as donor and guide; the golden lotus as a magical instrument; Sujit as the struggling hero; and restoration of the kingdom as final resolution. This does not claim that every one of Propp's functions appears in every story. Structural similarity makes interpretation easier; it does not establish that the work is a copy of any European folktale.

What really matters is that the author expands the sequence of folktale events into a long novel. Multiple levels of villainy, varied types of helper, and an external storyteller make its structure more complex than a single conventional folktale.

Rasa, Visuality, and the Child's Imagination

The dominant emotion of the story is heroism. The prince's frightening journey, confrontation with oppressive forces, and efforts to protect the subjects of the kingdom provide the basis of vira rasa, the heroic aesthetic mood. Yet courage is not merely the application of force: remaining disguised to gather information, making friends, and refraining from coercing an ally are also forms of prudent bravery.

Adbhuta rasa, the mood of wonder, emerges from the golden lotus, the protection of Mother Kali, the holy man's exceptional knowledge, and the episodes involving the demon. Bhayanaka rasa, the mood of fear, is present in Kallu's fort, abduction, the risks of the forest, and conspiracies. Karuna rasa, the mood of compassion and sorrow, is clear in Sunanda's separation from Sujit, King Ranvir Singh's predicament, and the suffering of ordinary people. The final reunion moves towards the easing of tension.

The author's visual world contains rivers, mountains, lakes, forests, and forts, chiefly serving to generate movement and excitement. Detailed treatments of local natural history, the weather, regional plant life, and the specific geography of Mithila are comparatively scarce. The adventurous character of the narrative partly justifies such brevity, but a closer relationship

between the mother tongue and regional environment might have given the novel a more distinct local form.

Moral Philosophy: Justice, Forgiveness, Consent, and Power

The novel's moral demand is active resistance to injustice. Sujit does not endure humiliation and wait passively. He prepares, gathers courage, accepts help, and protects people in danger. Virtue in the novel is therefore connected not only with words but with action.

Nevertheless, the difference between justice and vengeance is not always sufficiently clear. Kallu's destruction, the suppression of conspirators, and the restoration of dynastic succession occur together. In discussing these episodes with children, one may ask: when is force necessary for self-defence? How much forgiveness is proper after someone confesses a crime? Are personal forgiveness and public accountability the same or different?

Nayanavati's final remorse opens the novel's compassionate moral dimension. The possibility of personal transformation is an optimistic outlook useful for children's literature. But the judicial redress due to ordinary people harmed by political conspiracy is not automatically accomplished through personal forgiveness. The novel does not explore this difference deeply.

The question of consent becomes visible in the final section. Sujit's statement to Sar-Sultan that he will not "compel" him indicates that respecting an ally's free will is a virtue of moral leadership (Mishra, 2019: 97). This episode makes him a more thoughtful character than a simplified "hero with a sword."

The final restoration of the kingdom is presented as ideal kingship. In a modern democratic sense, the accountability of civic institutions receives comparatively little attention. The novel's political imagination relies chiefly upon the ethics of a worthy ruler. Even while recognizing this limitation, its sharp criticism of the misuse of official power remains an important achievement.

Child Psychology, the Reading Experience, and Educational Value

The curiosity of the children within the story assumes that a child is not merely a being who obeys instructions but a reader who asks questions. Prafull's request to hear a missed episode again, Vimala's doubts, and Rahul's questions create a many-sided experience of collective reading. Discussion, recollection, inference, and final response are all involved in how children construct meaning.

The adventurous structure does not eliminate fear altogether; it creates opportunities to make decisions in the presence of fear. The prince finds himself alone, may meet the wrong people, and cannot be certain of refuge. Such episodes may help develop a child's conception of the relationship between self-confidence and caution. Nevertheless, Kallu's violence and

episodes of abduction should be contextualized according to prospective young readers' age and sensitivity.

Children's reading depends not only on age but also on linguistic proficiency, experience of listening, and emotional readiness. The work is potentially appropriate for readers from the early years of secondary school through adolescence; for younger children, collective storytelling with selected episodes would be more useful. This is an evaluation of readership, not a definite age category specified by the publisher.

The availability of an extended adventure novel of this kind in the mother tongue is especially important for linguistic confidence. A Maithili child can experience the fact that palaces, demons, secret missions, political conflicts, and intimate domestic conversations may all be developed together in their own language. Children's literature becomes here a means of expanding the creative possibilities of the mother tongue.

Language, Dialogue, and Editorial Discipline

The novel's language suits natural storytelling. Frequent dialogue sustains the movement of events. The grandmother's manner of speaking has intimacy; the language of the royal characters conveys formality and authority. These differences make it easy for readers to enter both worlds.

There are also stylistic limitations. On many occasions, characters' dialogue merely communicates information required by the plot. When the narrator or holy man immediately explains the moral meaning of events, readers have less opportunity to interpret for themselves. A better balance between dramatic scenes and inward experience would have deepened the effect.

From an editorial perspective, certain descriptions and repetitions could be shortened, but it would be inappropriate to standardize Maithili word forms, sentence rhythms, and the oral voice unnecessarily. The naturalness of the language is itself part of the work's creative wealth.

Critical Limitations and a Balanced Evaluation

The work's first limitation is its extended introduction. Its domestic opening is culturally meaningful, but the main adventure begins comparatively late. A second limitation is the excessive idealization of the hero: Sujit has limited opportunities to display human weakness or make mistaken decisions. A third is dependence on magical protection, which sometimes simplifies the complexities of human endeavour.

A fourth limitation is the incomplete development of the antagonists' motivations. Nayanavati and Jalim Singh clearly represent a lust for power, but their inner conflicts and social circumstances might have been explored more deeply. Kallu's past offers the possibility of breaking this simplification, but does not receive sustained development.

A fifth limitation is the unequal distribution of agency by gender. The grandmother and Vishakha are decisive in the creation of meaning, but men

remain the principal leaders of physical expeditions and political solutions. A sixth is the rapid resolution of the final political order and of questions of punishment and justice. Amid family reconciliation, public justice and the rights of the people become secondary.

Pointing out these limitations does not diminish the work. The purpose of literary criticism is to reveal both a composition's actual structure and its possibilities. Evaluation must take into account its folktale aims, young readers' need for excitement, and the historical circumstances of the published Maithili children's novel.

Achievements: The Creative Expansion of the Maithili Children's Novel

The first achievement of Swarna Kamal is its renewal of oral storytelling culture. The portrayal of the reading relationship between the grandmother and the children forms the novel's original cultural voice. A second achievement is its sustained adventure plot extending through several sections, in which the prince's journey, palace conspiracy, the demon's reign of terror, and restoration of the kingdom become interrelated.

A third achievement is the expansion of the moral definition of courage. Helping strangers, winning trustworthy companions, gathering secret intelligence, and respecting consent are presented alongside heroism. A fourth is its combination of the marvellous, fearful, heroic, and compassionate emotional experiences, which broaden young readers' imaginative powers.

A fifth achievement is the expansion of prose in the mother tongue. Formal dialogue in the royal court coexists in the same book with the grandmother's affectionate Maithili. A sixth is the variety of moral questions: how to administer justice, whom to trust, how to treat someone who has chosen a wrong path, and why moral fitness matters more than entitlement.

Taken as a whole, the work is not only a story of a prince's victory but also a literary affirmation of children's right to listen, question, and think.

Conclusion

The most justifiable generic designation for Swarna Kamal is a folktale-based adventure novel in Maithili children's literature. Its fundamental movement lies in the prince's dangerous journey, but its cultural originality resides in the storytelling relationship between the grandmother and Prafull. Through this two-level structure, the work brings together the intimacy of oral tradition and the extended world of adventure in the printed novel.

Sujit's victory acquires a meaning more complex than a simple assertion that "good triumphs over evil." His struggle raises questions of justice, trust, cooperation, and consent. At the same time, the idealized hero, decisive intervention by wonders, limited independence of women characters, and dynastic resolution provoke modern critical questions.

Despite these contradictions, the book's enduring literary contribution remains significant. Within the narrative, the flower that gives the book its

title is a means of protection and hope; in critical terms, it becomes a symbol of stories, memories, and moral imagination passed between generations within the Maithili mother tongue. The royal adventure comes to an end, but the children's desire to hear their grandmother's stories points to the continuity of literature.

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Integrated Conclusion

Literary Achievements and Critical Limitations

Reading these twelve works together reveals Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand's authorial identity chiefly as an effort to bring society's internal contradictions into public discussion. His language and narrative arrangement change across the genres of short fiction, novels, literary sketches, songs, and children's narratives, yet his commitment to human dignity, education, opposition to injustice, and relationships among people remains constant.

The reformist tendency is a significant achievement of his writing. Its limitation becomes visible when the voice of the narrator or a character overwhelms the artistic scene and predetermines the conclusion. Depictions of women's identity, the lives of disadvantaged groups, rural institutions, and modern administration often generate questions, while in certain episodes

their solutions arrive too rapidly through a character's moral steadfastness. This difference matters in the critical evaluation of every work.

The village and the city in Mithila are not merely opposing poles here. Memory, education, livelihood, migration, political experience, and cultural activities sustain constant movement between them. On this social ground, Nand's literature makes human relationships its chief measure. Its critical possibilities lie in maintaining a balance: affection for village culture must not become uncritical attachment, and trust in modern institutions must not obscure questions about their structures of power.

Kavya Sarita and Swarna Kamal are particular evidence of the author's creative range. The former brings together lyric tradition, folk melodies, and public consciousness; the latter transforms family storytelling and adventurous imagination into an extended narrative for young readers. It would be inappropriate to examine both without modification against the criteria used for adult social novels: every genre has its own aesthetics and expectations of readership.

Overall, Nand's body of work offers abundant opportunities to study social questions, expression rooted in the language of ordinary people, and moral imagination within Maithili literature. Its importance lies not in declarations of praise but in the questions that compel readers to reconsider the relationships among equality, justice, family, power, morality, and linguistic culture.

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STUDY 06 / NIT NAVAL

Kumar Pawan

Kumar Pawan: Narrative, Society and Ethical Questions

In Kumar Pawan's fictional world, human beings frequently stand on a threshold where personal desire confronts the rules constructed by society. In one place there is a row of guests at a feast; elsewhere, a college office; elsewhere still, an aspiration to become acquainted with an influential person. The settings change, but the underlying concern remains the same: how does an individual preserve dignity, independence and moral discernment? Read together, these three works reveal the multidimensional range of Kumar Pawan's narrative vision.

Against the background of a popular religious belief that the departed soul must gain admission to heaven, 'Paith' exposes the contradiction between the hunger of the living and ostentation after death. While alive, Kaniya Kaki asked for a little food for her daughter's son, and an uproar arose in the household and community; after her death, however, an enormous feast was arranged in the hope of securing her soul's admission to heaven. 'The Blank Pages of a Diary' tells of the entanglements of power, education and personal self-writing. 'The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal' begins by searching for the meaning of a popular saying and moves towards the irony of society's hunger for office and intellectual prestige. In all three works, laughter, astonishment, compassion and irony are not opposing forces but different registers of a single reality.

This book presents separate critical readings of the three works in sequence. It then offers a literary-theoretical comparison of narrative time, memory, point of view, social power and ethical responsibility in 'Paith' and 'The Blank Pages of a Diary'. To call 'Paith' the Maithili equivalent of 'Usne Kaha Tha' is not to suggest a similarity in plot or technique; the comparison concerns a particular kind of literary renown. Just as Chandradhar Sharma Guleri is particularly well known for 'Usne Kaha Tha', a single story can become the representative work associated with a writer's name. In relation to 'Paith', the analogy should be understood in this restricted sense alone.

The purpose of criticism is not to pass judgment on the virtues and failings of characters, but to clarify the many voices, memories, social calculations and unresolved questions within a literary work. When a narrative offers no definite answer, its silence can itself become meaningful. Kumar Pawan's writings demand precisely this uncomfortable yet necessary activity from their readers.

PART I

Paith

Neglect of the Living, the Funeral Feast and the Irony of Admission to Heaven

Inside the Work

Kumar Pawan's ‘Paith’ is an example of the Maithili long story in which preparations for a feast following a death, the commotion surrounding it and the display of social standing expose the unequal structure of rural society. Its poignant contradiction is that when Kaniya Kaki, during her lifetime, asked for a little food for her daughter's son, her request caused an uproar; after her death, however, an enormous feast is organised in accordance with the popular belief that the soul should gain ‘paith’, or admission, to heaven. Sarwan Babu's arrangements and the arguments they provoke are intertwined with the neglect Kaniya Kaki suffered while alive, family relationships, expectations of inheritance and lineage, dreams of education and future life, the public crowd and the sequence of meals. The title does not primarily mean entry into the place of feasting; it expresses the desire for religious acceptance of the dead soul into heaven. Its irony emerges from the contrast between an ignored appeal to satisfy the hunger of the living and extravagant expenditure in the name of the dead. This study examines narrative construction, dialogue, satire, women's perspectives, caste and class relations, the symbolism of food and ethical unease. It also offers a comparison of genres using materials on infant folklore, children's folktales, illustrated stories and modern children's novels available through Videha. The aim is not to declare this long story a work of children's literature, but to establish the differences in implied readership, narrative language and modes of representing social reality.

Introduction: Feasts after Death in Mithila and Responsibility towards the Living

In the rural world of Maithili fiction, the veranda, courtyard, pond, pathway, field, market and communal feast are not merely geographical or cultural locations; they make visible the rules, hierarchies, distances and conflicts of society. ‘Paith’ gives this familiar experience an unusual narrative scope. The feast associated with the popular religious hope that a departed soul will gain admission to heaven becomes a communal undertaking. Behind this spectacle lies a modest request Kaniya Kaki made while still alive—food for her daughter's son. The memory of the uproar caused by that request renders the grand funeral feast ethically unsettling. The village darkness, pathways, movement of people and assembled community give visible form to this inversion.

To treat ‘Paith’ merely as a report on food scarcity or as a one-dimensional indictment of the caste system would diminish its many voices. Its central

satire is not directed against religious ritual itself, but against the forgetting of obligations to a person neglected in life while displaying generosity after her death. The writer moves between scenes of feasting and family memories, public postures and private distress, ludicrous conduct and compassionate moments. The result is not a tale with one identifiable villain but a record of the fractured moral consciousness of communal life. The question arises: why could a society so eager to obtain heavenly admission for a departed soul not respond with ordinary humanity to the simple request of Kaniya Kaki while she lived?

The Title ‘Paith’: The Soul's Admission to Heaven and Ethical Irony

In this story, ‘paith’ does not refer to joining a row of diners at the feast; it denotes the popular religious idea that the soul, after death, should find a place or acceptance in heaven. When Kaniya Kaki was alive, she requested a little food for her daughter's son; even this small need provoked an uproar within the family and community. After her death, an immense feast was arranged in the belief that she should obtain ‘paith’ in heaven. These two scenes constitute the heart of the title: severity towards the modest hunger of the living and a spectacular abundance of food in the interests of the dead person's afterlife. In this sense, though ‘paith’ names a religious purpose, it also becomes a measure of the distance between actual service to human beings and the prestige attached to ritual.

The title's satirical force lies in the question of why it was so difficult to give food to Kaniya Kaki's daughter's son during her lifetime, when elaborate arrangements for a feast became possible after her death in the hope of assuring her soul a place in heaven. Religious belief retains its place within the narrative; criticism is directed at conduct that incurs expense for welfare in the afterlife but makes a little hunger among the living a cause for uproar. The dining rows, rice, crowd and social status provide visible means of expressing this central contradiction; they do not supply the primary meaning of the title.

A Social Map of the Narrative World

One axis of the narrative is Sarwan Babu's organisation of the feast after death and the public community surrounding it. Arrangements for food, invitations, cooking hearths and kitchens, workers, prominent local figures and communal expectations depend upon one another. The second axis is the neglect Kaniya Kaki experienced in life: the uproar following her request for a little food for her daughter's son, relationships among sons, daughters-in-law and other family members, Gunja, prestige and the absence of affection. Between these axes the distance opens up between the wish for the dead soul's admission to heaven and duty towards a living member of the family. Here the public feast and the private family are not separate realms; they are two manifestations of the moral values of the same society.

Through the differences of opinion among Raghav, helpers, contractors, organisers and other characters, the narrative at various points presents the rural community in the plural. The writer does not depend solely upon a single character to pronounce an authorial verdict. People sometimes argue, sometimes speculate, sometimes fear, and at other times remain indifferent to another's suffering. The crowd is not an inert background but an active character in the story.

Reading the Narrative: The Opening Collective Scene

The configuration of the opening scenes brings together darkness, movement along the road, village discussion, anticipation of the feast and activity on the veranda. Although the scene appears momentarily still, people's conversations and occupations keep it in motion. Rather than disclose the principal event immediately and completely, the writer raises the social temperature. Through this technique, readers do not simply receive news; they experience a situation taking shape within its surroundings. First comes the village, then the feast, and then the dispositions dependent upon the feast.

In this passage the feast after death resembles a ‘social experiment’: everyone assembles in the name of fulfilling a collective religious obligation, but no one sees it in exactly the same way. In the very place where a ritual is performed for the welfare of a departed soul, rank, prestige and pride find expression. The narrator does not insert an extended theory to explain the complexity of social relations; the conversation of one person, the response of another and the preparations of a third gradually construct the social order. The memory of the dispute over a modest request made during Kaniya Kaki's lifetime calls into question the brilliance of this collective rite.

Reading the Narrative: The Feast Crowd and the Irony of Valour

By this point, the crowd is no longer merely a matter of numbers; it becomes a measure by which conduct is judged. The distance increases between a feast arranged to secure the soul's admission to heaven and the demands of public decorum. Those who speak of civilisation, religion, tradition and hospitality find their patience and restraint imperilled by questions about the rows of diners. The discrepancy between the language of ‘valour’ and actual behaviour at the feast produces satire. True courage ought to mean standing with the helpless while they are alive; here the grand provision for the next world stands in stark opposition to the uproar caused by an ordinary appeal for food.

It would be mistaken to dismiss this episode as mere exaggeration. Within collective consumption, the writer reveals a conflict between the sense of entitlement and the experience of humiliation. Food served at the funeral feast becomes a display of ritual obligation; in Kaniya Kaki's request during her lifetime, the same food was simply a means of satisfying her daughter's son's hunger. Who sits first, who receives a welcome, who is accommodated

and who must wait—these are all social and political questions. The writer places all four levels within the compass of satire.

Reading the Narrative: Fire, Water, Iron, Stone and Collective Confusion

Here the intensity of the setting increases. The road, railway tracks, frantic movement, apprehension and spreading news become intertwined. The arrangement of scenes sustains uncertainty about what will happen next. At such moments, people's social masks fall away: one is concerned with survival, another pursues each new report, while a third tries to understand the event in relation to home and family. The crisis ceases to be purely individual and becomes a test of collective consciousness.

The narrator maintains a distance between an event and the news of it. What people hear may not be the complete truth, yet the effects of the report are real. At this point satire collides with compassion. When a community that makes a commotion over the slightest disruption to ritual panics in the face of insecurity, the story asks: how will society protect its collective judgment? This section matters not merely because it creates excitement but because it exposes the fragility of communal relationships.

Reading the Narrative: Kaniya Kaki's Request, Neglect and the Generational Divide

The story shifts its centre through memories of Kaniya Kaki's life. It moves from the collective spectacle of the feast after death into the realm of private tenderness, family obligations and frustrated aspirations. The uproar provoked by her wish to obtain a little food for her daughter's son reveals the true face of the family's system of values. Her suffering is consequently not merely a sentimental episode; it is the ethical centre of the plot. Why could a society capable of holding an elaborate feast to secure the soul's admission to heaven after death not honour a living woman's modest, affectionate wish? This question echoes throughout the narrative.

Episodes concerning education, hopes for the future, family support and changing generations prevent ‘Paith’ from remaining simply the story of a single day's funeral feast. The present arrangements are accompanied by memories of indignity, affection, deprivation and struggle in her lifetime. The narrative therefore breaks the straight line of time: the scenes of the feast after death repeatedly recall the ignored request of the living woman. The wish for ‘paith’ in the next world and neglect in this world confront each other within one narrative time.

Reading the Narrative: Windows, Aspiration and Psychological Tension

A reading of this episode reveals numerous suggestions of looking through a window, gazing outward from within and interpreting external events through personal suffering. The ‘window’ becomes a boundary between vision

and distance. Outside is the commotion of the crowd; inside, an individual explores frustrated desire, the expectation of entitlement and the meaning of relationships. Memories of Kaniya Kaki and the younger generation's concerns about the family meet at this threshold.

The main artistic achievement of this section is that the questions moving through a character's mind do not become definitive pronouncements by the narrator. In some episodes the character argues in defence of a decision; in others, the character is himself or herself surrounded by questions. Such ambiguity strengthens psychological credibility. Yet the narrative may appear to slow for some readers, as prolonged inward reflection moves somewhat away from the public plot. This is both a strength and a risk of the technique.

Reading the Narrative: Gunja, Inheritance and Inequality within the Family

Here the conflicts among Gunja and other family members form another major strand of the narrative's social world. Sons, daughters, daughters-in-law, mothers and others counted as ‘one's own’ do not receive equal emotional importance. Someone who inspires hope for the future may become, within family calculations, an object, an obligation or a cause of dispute. The writer's gaze moves from the feast outside to the ‘division’ within the home.

This episode can be read in connection with the wider pressures of women's lives. A woman's role is commonly defined as an inexhaustible source of affection, someone who fulfils others' expectations and bears the honour of the household; how far her own wishes or exhaustion will be recognised, however, remains uncertain. This contradiction produces the narrative's underlying sorrow. Gunja's story suggests the possibility of hope for a woman's future, but that hope is not itself free of the constraints of patriarchal relations.

Reading the Narrative: From a Request for Food in Life to a Feast after Death

The poignancy of the narrative resides in the strange inequality between the quantity of food and the moment at which it is provided. During her lifetime Kaniya Kaki asked for a little food for her daughter's son, and the request caused an uproar. After her death, however, a huge feast was arranged to secure her soul's ‘paith’ in heaven. Here rice is both a basic necessity of life and a public instrument of ritual observance after death. The grain that could readily have been given to satisfy a living person's hunger is served in abundance by a society seeking acceptance for the dead in the next world. This contradiction is the deep ethical question of the narrative enterprise.

At the close, descriptions of the sickly moonlight, darkness, sounds and rural atmosphere lend gravity to the story's satire. The successive servings of the funeral feast and the people waiting for them form a structure in which the question of duty towards living human beings persists even after the ritual has been completed. Behind the arrangements intended to secure Kaniya

Kaki's heavenly admission, the insult inflicted on her modest request in life continues to resonate. The ending is not a monument to resolution but the residue of an ethical question.

Narrative time thus revolves around two axes: Kaniya Kaki's hunger, affection and neglect during life, and the great feast held after her death in the hope of gaining admission to heaven for her soul. These opposed scenes are not ornamental incidents but a subtle commentary upon society's hierarchy of values. Can the ordinary obligation evaded during a person's lifetime truly be discharged through magnificence after death? The story keeps this question alive in the reader's mind.

The Politics of Feasting: The Dead Soul's Admission and the Neglect of the Living

The feast after death in Mithila is presented in relation to popular religious beliefs, family standing and communal expectations. The stated purpose of the ritual is to secure the departed soul's admission to heaven; yet pressures remain concerning who receives honour, where each person sits, who must wait and who must be invited. The irony of the arrangements in 'Paith' is not merely the inequality of the dining rows, but that Kaniya Kaki's request for a little food for her daughter's son caused uproar while she lived, whereas a vast feast became possible after she died.

The illusion that communal consumption automatically constitutes compassionate solidarity breaks down here. The resources devoted to a great feast attest to ritual enthusiasm; justice and sensitivity towards living human beings require a different measure. The narrative is not a treatise that proves or disproves the validity of religious belief. Instead, it asks why a community so active in seeking heavenly admission for a departed soul was intolerant of her modest wish in life. From this perspective, whose words were heard, whose needs recognised and whose suffering overlooked become the actual concerns of the story's examination of power in its subtle forms.

Women's Perspectives: Kaniya Kaki's Neglect in Life and Honour after Death

At the public level, the voices of male characters and the language of organisation, controversy and authority are heard more often. Yet the depth of private suffering emerges through Kaniya Kaki. The uproar over her affectionate request for food during her lifetime shows how readily a woman's wishes may be rejected within the home. The magnificent feast arranged after her death for the sake of her soul's admission to heaven stands as the inverse of this neglect. The absence of justice inside the household is not an occurrence separate from the public ritual: both reveal the same social order of values.

Kaniya Kaki's experience is the measure of the story's humane conscience. When the prestige of the event, its abundant food and the noise of the crowd are compared with the treatment she received while alive, the hierarchy of values changes. Making elaborate arrangements for a departed soul's

admission to heaven may be part of communal religious belief, but creating an uproar over a living woman's modest request is a failure of human obligation. In this irony, the woman's suffering becomes a silent protest against the spectacle.

A critical limitation must also be acknowledged. To deepen the reader's sympathy, the narrative repeatedly invokes motherhood and sacrifice; the question therefore remains how directly an independent voice of women's rights is articulated. The story's moral awareness places women's suffering at the centre, but the full extent of their power to make decisions is not equally clear everywhere. Recognising this limitation prevents criticism from becoming unqualified praise.

Language, Dialogue and the Narrative Art of Satire

'Paith' is rich in dialogue. Speech rhythms, exchanges of questions and answers, apprehension, urgency, the repetition of another's words and contrasting responses to the same matter all create the narrative movement. Rather than offer a standardised exposition, the writer unfolds the action through numerous popular voices. Preparations for the feast consequently resemble at different moments a public meeting, a domestic quarrel or a crossroads where rumours spread. The pressure of authentic rural experience within the language strengthens the work's credibility.

A distinctive stylistic feature is the swift alternation between satire and compassion. An episode that first makes the reader laugh becomes unsettling upon closer examination. The writer casts an oblique eye upon crowds, declarations, valour, discipline, fear and needless concern for prestige. Yet the target of satire is neither the hungry human being nor the reverence attached to funeral observances; it is the inversion of values whereby Kaniya Kaki's simple request for food while alive became a dispute, while a grand feast for her heavenly admission after death was considered a social duty.

There are also risks in the technique. The continuous sequence of many dialogues and rapid shifts from one episode to another can make it difficult for a new reader to identify the characters and their situations. At some points extended psychological analysis adopts a tempo different from the swift progress of public events. But such unevenness of rhythm cannot be regarded as an unqualified fault, for the story itself is composed of unequal social times: the crowd demands an immediate decision, while the wounded mind wanders through prolonged memories.

The Presence of Images: A Parallel Visual Language with the Reader

The original narrative passages contain many black-and-white illustrations. Decorative frames, eyes, women's faces, animal figures, elephants and the rhythmic configurations of folk imagery create an aesthetic level independent of the story. The recurring image of the eye, in particular, may be read in relation to the problems of looking, being seen and failing to see even while

looking. The densely filled forms of folk art create a visual parallel to the crowd and intricate relationships of the narrative.

It would be mistaken to treat the illustrations as realistic replicas of every narrative scene. They are primarily suggestive. The prose unfolds the contradictions of social relations in words, while the lines of the drawings bring symbolic density. In a children's book, illustrations may facilitate comprehension of the story; in 'Paith' they chiefly produce layers of meaning and atmosphere. Their different function means that the mere presence of illustrations does not turn 'Paith' into children's literature.

The History of Maithili Children's Literature in the Light of Available Videha Materials

To regard modern published picture stories as the beginning of Maithili children's literature would be to read its history incompletely. In 'Maithili Shishu Lok Sahitya', published by Phoolchandra Jha 'Praveen' in Videha, issue 50 (2010), the forms of folk expression associated with child-rearing, games and the acquisition of knowledge receive extended treatment. The article stresses the importance of household and courtyard, folk songs, lullabies, oral traditions of play and linguistic memory transmitted across generations. This material makes clear that the history of children's literature is not simply a list of authors and publication dates; it is also a study of the transition from oral tradition to the printed book.

Dr Yoganand Jha's 'Maithili Ballokkatha: Sthiti aa Apeksha' [Maithili Children's Folktales: Present Condition and Expectations], in Videha, issue 76 (2011), focuses on the collection of folktales, the needs of the child's mind, the accessibility of narrative language and the importance of compilation. Jha mentions the first edition (1983) and expanded edition (2006) of Ramlochan Thakur's 'Maithili Lokkatha' and raises the issue of preserving the language of oral storytelling. He considers Preeti Thakur's illustrated stories a bridge between folktales and a new readership. From this perspective, the development of writing for children can be understood as an interrelated process of orality, collection, rewriting, illustration and criticism.

Videha's catalogue of children's literature lists Preeti Thakur's original works 'Gonu Jha aa Aan Maithili Chitrakatha' (2008), 'Maithili Chitrakatha' (2009), 'Mithilak Lokdevata' (2010) and 'Vidyapatik Purush Pariksha' (2012), alongside numerous translated books for children. This offers a glimpse of renewed publishing initiatives linking pictures, folk narratives and young readers from the first part of the 2000s onward. Durganand Mandal's 'Nena Lel Sundar Chitrakatha' (Videha, issue 116, 2012) reviews these efforts in illustrated storytelling.

From a newer perspective, Gajendra Thakur's 'Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra', published in Videha, issue 447 (1 August 2026), discusses criteria for assessing different kinds of children's novels, narratives of folk heroes, instructional stories and modern imaginative writing. Rather than restrict the criticism of children's literature to 'moral instruction', it extends

critical criteria to readers' age, narration, cultural representation and aesthetic considerations. A fuller account of this history needs to bring together older folk traditions, collections of the 1980s, picture books of 2008–2012 and the modern critical framework.

This chronology is not intended as a definitive history of all Maithili children's literature. It presents a comparative view based on selected Videha sources examined here. Claims about the first publication of other books or the literary precedence of particular authors would require a broader library catalogue; this essay makes no such unverified claims.

'Paith' and Stories for Children: A Shared Cultural World, Different Implied Readers

The similarities between 'Paith' and Maithili children's folktales are first found in language and setting: the village, family, everyday speech, food, memory, livelihood and mutual dependence. Children's stories also draw their material from these elements. Their narrative purposes, however, differ. In children's folktales, a concise plot, visual clarity, curiosity, repetition and an emotional organisation appropriate to the reader's age are often important. 'Paith', by contrast, privileges multilayered social irony, slow introspection, tense accusations, burdensome relationships and an open ethical conclusion. It would therefore be inappropriate to call the work suitable for children without adaptation.

The symbolism of food offers an especially revealing comparison. In infant folk songs, milk and rice, flattened rice, sohari bread and other foods are frequently associated with affection, nurture and the celebration of life. In 'Paith', a little grain requested for a daughter's son becomes a cause of family controversy, while an abundant feast becomes possible for the dead soul's admission to heaven. The same cultural object acquires different meanings in different contexts: for a child, food is an immediate necessity of affection and care; at the feast after death, it is a sign of ritual prestige. Literary criticism reveals the ethical difference between these two meanings.

A comparison of the illustrations is equally instructive. According to Durganand Mandal's review, picture stories for children help them recognise folk traditions and grasp the meaning of stories. The illustrations in 'Paith' do not offer only such simple visual cues; they create symbolic responses to the complex emotional terrain of the prose. The comparison shows that a work's suitability for children cannot be judged solely by the presence or absence of pictures. Plot, linguistic density, the representation of social violence and the reader's interpretive capacity must all be considered.

The Work's Achievements and Critical Limitations

The first achievement of 'Paith' is that it turns a feast intended to secure a dead soul's admission to heaven into a miniature model of society's system of values. The second is the sharp opposition between the uproar over Kaki's modest request for food while alive and the splendour of the arrangements

after her death. The third is the movement between collective scenes and private distress, through which the characters' experiences become historical and emotional rather than merely eventful. The fourth is its capacity to raise ethical questions through satire without immediately preaching. The fifth is the vitality of the vernacular and the symbolic presence of illustrations. The open ending prompts readers to examine themselves.

These achievements do not remove critical questions. Because the narrative contains many voices, separating the narrator's perspective from the opinions of characters can at times demand considerable effort; some dialogue places a heavy burden on the reader's attention. Although women's suffering is depicted powerfully, the scope of their active self-determination may remain comparatively limited. The indications of social class and caste are sharp, yet the distinct psychological situation of every character is not developed to the same degree. The transition from the speed of the opening crowd scenes to the family memories of the middle passages may also prove effective or difficult in different ways for different readers.

A weak interpretation of the story's final ethical tension would be to say that 'everyone is bad'. The writer does not construct such a universal condemnation. The community also contains the possibilities of cooperation, kindness, familial hope and intimacy; the crisis is that the structures of social standing continually diminish those possibilities. Preserving this subtle opposition is essential to an adequate reading of the story.

Conclusion: Admission to the Next World and Unfulfilled Duties in This One

The power of 'Paith' as a long story lies in its transformation of the religious idea of a dead soul's admission to heaven into a test of ethical responsibility towards the living. Kaniya Kaki asked for a little food for her daughter's son while she was alive, but the request provoked an uproar; after her death, a large feast was arranged for her soul's admission to heaven. The opposition between these events gives the title its poignant meaning. As readers observe the rows of diners, they begin to perceive the ranks assigned to human worth. Sarwan Babu's arrangements form the centre of the public spectacle, while Kaniya Kaki's experience of life becomes its ethical counterpoint.

The darkness, arrangements for the feast, crowds, anxieties, family grief, the need for a little food in life and the arrangements for admission to heaven after death unite two times in the narrative and resist a simplistic romanticisation of rural Maithili life. The village is a place of beautiful memories, but it is also a social order full of contradictions. The writer's satire reveals this double truth at once: the public declaration of reverence and the absence of sensitivity towards the living.

The comparative history of children's literature further clarifies this conclusion. The same folk culture offers children lullabies, curiosity and illustrated stories, and offers adult readers satire, contradiction and critical

self-examination. The distinctiveness of ‘Paith’ resides in the latter kind of reading experience. The distance between food requested for a daughter's son during a woman's lifetime and the feast held after her death for heavenly admission becomes, more than a question of religious observance, a question of justice towards living human beings.

PART II

The Blank Pages of a Diary

Educational Institutions, Power, Self-Writing and Moral Discernment

Inside the Work

Kumar Pawan's ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’ is a long story in which the desire to write about oneself continually clashes with the pressures of public institutional life. At its centre stands a college principal, a man oscillating among administrative achievement, the desire for prestige, political connections, fear, disillusionment and introspection. The story begins with the habit of keeping a diary, but develops into an intricate account of college construction, teachers' appointments, examinations, student politics, interventions by influential local figures, and public allegations and counter-allegations. The blank page is not simply an image of an inability to write; it represents a crisis of self-testimony for a person entangled in power. This study examines the sequence of narrative episodes, character conception, modes of narration, satire, linguistic devices and the arrangement of illustrations. The history of children's literature is discussed with due regard for the limits of comparison: the work is not a children's story, but it enters into a useful dialogue with writing for children on the ethics of educational institutions, student agency and illustrated storytelling.

Introduction: The Double Meaning of Emptiness

A diary is generally taken to be an orderly record of private experience. Its pages are expected to bear witness to an individual's time: what was seen, which decisions were made, what mistakes occurred and what a person concealed in the mind. Kumar Pawan reverses this familiar assumption. His protagonist believes in the prestige of writing, but the social and administrative complications of the very life that supplies him with material for writing continually prevent him from doing so. The emptiness of the title is therefore not confined to paper; it is also an absence of self-knowledge, moral steadiness and an honest record.

At the beginning, the work identifies its genre as a ‘long story’. This designation matters because its arrival of characters, changing circumstances and widening struggles for power extend beyond the single event of a short story, without constructing the autonomous and expansive world of a novel. Its repetitive, question-filled and dialogue-rich prose sets the principal's mental turmoil alongside institutional disorder.

The central proposition of this critical reading is that the story confronts two contradictory desires in the individual: the wish to record one's life meaningfully and the impulse to evade its uncomfortable truths in order to protect one's public image. The literary effect arises from this opposition. Moral instruction does not become the author's declared conclusion; it emerges indirectly from the character's experience.

The Development of the Story: Principal Episodes

The Diary Habit and the Dream of Personal Distinction

The narrative begins by introducing the practice of diary writing. The private writings of a high-school teacher, the desire to see one's life one day transformed into an important book, and the social recognition accorded to writing are joined from the outset. The diary is both a companion in solitude and an instrument for becoming worthy of future readers. With the principal's appearance, literary ambition becomes bound to the desire for social advancement.

Construction, Prestige and the Obstruction of Writing

The principal's routine becomes increasingly occupied with the expansion of college buildings, groups of students, local contacts and administrative projects. The absence of time is not simply physical busyness; the prestige associated with his work becomes more attractive than private record-keeping. The principal promises to record the day's experiences, but his self-testimony fails to take shape on paper. From this point, the problem of blank pages becomes a problem of character.

Ambition, Calculation and Cracks in Self-Confidence

The conflict between public recognition and private hesitation grows sharper. The principal sees opportunities in his relationships with the institution, university, students and influential people. The recurring intrusion of apprehensions, comparisons, conjectures and questions into the narrative exposes his internal instability. Speculation about his future becomes more important than reasoned decisions.

Proof of Authority and the Fear of Humiliation

Protecting prestige becomes directly connected with administrative authority. The principal fears that others will not accord him the elevated status he assigns to himself. The need for external validation grows stronger than the autonomy of his personality. Here the story's humour assumes a compassionate significance: even after acquiring power, a person may remain inwardly insecure.

An Encounter with an Influential Figure and the Test of Self-Restraint

The principal's closeness to centres of political and social influence changes the story's tone. A relationship with someone such as Brindavan Babu offers not only opportunities but also occasions on which fidelity to values is tested. The principal's responses reveal contradictions among affection, fear, risk and

self-interest. The illustrations provide a satirical visual parallel to the emotional condition of this episode.

Wandering in Search of Causes

Anxiety to understand the relation between cause and effect takes the principal from personal ethical questions into social and philosophical debate. Reflections on religion, politics, revolution and educational life intermingle. Because superficial knowledge offers no reliable remedy, the search continually returns in the form of questions. At this point the long story stands at the crossroads of introspection and intellectual satire.

Usha Ji and a Moment of New Possibility

Usha Ji's presence in the university environment momentarily draws the principal's attention away from his defensive posture. He is inspired to reconsider his conduct, intellectual pursuits and social relationships. Yet this experience does not demonstrate any permanent moral transformation; the story retains it as a possibility. The female character suggests a new point of view, although her own autonomous life is not developed at sufficient length.

Public Morality and Private Insecurity

Religious scenes, social identities, campus activities and the distribution of pamphlets again challenge the principal's assurances. Popular religiosity, prestige and the fear of condemnation converge. His reactions make it clear that he first sees a crisis as a threat to his honour and only later as a matter of institutional truth. The illustrations accompanying this episode provide emblematic expressions of solitude and uncertainty.

The College, Rumour and the Politics of Accusation

Alongside the principal's plans for the campus comes a provocative incident in which public morality becomes an instrument of propaganda against the institution. The distance between rumour, suggestion, material evidence and accusation is deliberately blurred. The literary significance of the episode lies not in sensationalism but in the fact that suspicion begins to determine an institution's reputation before any verification of facts.

Examination Procedures, Appointments and the Traffic in Influence

Within the college, a network emerges connecting examinations, assessment, offices, promotions and resources of patronage. Dominant local figures such as Balli Babu influence internal institutional decisions. A pronounced tension appears between the formal procedures of educational administration and personal favours. The story does not merely denounce corrupt individuals; it demonstrates how institutions come to speak the language of private bargains.

The Changing Calculus of Political Patronage

Changes in factions, elections and patronage weaken the principal's earlier safeguards. A connection that proved beneficial yesterday may become a source of insecurity today. In this uncertainty, the conflict between his self-

respect and his fear intensifies. Power is not a stable protector but a name for shifting equations: this is what emerges from the sequence of incidents.

Pressure, Compromise and the Return of Fear

Questions of examinations and institutional autonomy sharpen conflicts among teachers, officials and local centres of influence. At times the principal speaks in the language of unequivocal opposition; at others, he is disturbed by the possibility of punishment. These oscillations prevent him from becoming an unchanging hero, revealing both human weakness and moral courage.

Student Agitation and the Disintegration of Public Image

Student groups, slogans, chaos on campus and outside involvement turn the administration of the college into a theatrical public stage. The voices raised against the principal do not all have the same meaning: some are forms of resistance, some opportunism, and some rumour. The story asks on what basis reality can be judged when every side seeks to shape its own public image. The caricatures visually confirm the trembling foundations of status and authority.

The Final Attempt at Self-Defence and the Return of the Blank Pages

Plans to manage the crisis, student politics, anxiety about prestige and the recurring question of self-writing come together in this episode. The story provides no easy resolution; it leaves readers facing the incompleteness of the principal's self-examination. The diary returns to the narrative foreground, but the pressures of the passing days may still prevent its pages from being filled. The title is no longer a mere synopsis of events: it has become an ethical metaphor for the story as a whole.

Plot Construction: From a Private Diary to the Story of a Public Institution

At first sight, the narrative resembles an account of the fluctuations of one person's state of mind; closer attention reveals the collective autobiography of an institution. What begins as the writer's solitude is gradually entered by students, teachers, administrators, political workers, local notables, the influence of journalism and anxieties about home and family. The central position of the principal's consciousness holds the narrative's expansion together, but the entire world does not remain under his control. Its movement derives from this contradiction.

A significant feature of the sequence of events is that no problem is ever completely resolved. Building construction is a social achievement but also invites political claims; political contacts enhance prestige while producing dependence; formal systems of examinations and appointments leave openings for personal interference; student activism can serve as resistance but also as a vehicle for other pressures. Thus the narrative substitutes continuous replacement for any lasting victory.

The story advances its central subject through numerous subplots, but they do not all stand at the same distance from the question of the diary. Some

administrative details occupy comparatively extensive space while the symbol of self-writing recedes. This is a formal limitation, because readers must reactivate the principal metaphor for themselves. Yet the advantage of this range is that the crisis of a self-absorbed individual ultimately appears as a structural crisis of an educational institution.

The Principal's Character: An Autonomous Individual or a Prisoner of Prestige?

The principal is the narrative's central character, but not a spotless hero in the traditional sense. Administrative competence, practical shrewdness, dreams of advancement, self-interest, fear for reputation, philosophical curiosity and moral hesitation are all present within him. At times he seems eager to change the system; at others, he benefits from it. This duality makes both criticism and sympathy possible.

The principal's inner world is governed largely by possible crises in the future. He fears not only actual events but also their potential consequences for his reputation. Continually seeking evidence of one's worth from other people, offices, patrons, institutional announcements and public approval creates dependence. The story thus exposes the contradiction between the social capital of prestige and self-respect.

His moments of self-transformation are genuine but fleeting. Whether through his contact with Usha Ji or thoughts of rising above self-interest, a new path briefly seems possible, only to be covered over by familiar equations of power. The writer therefore does not produce a tale of the hero's redemption but one of incomplete capacity for change. This incompleteness lends the ending ethical credibility.

Supporting Characters and the Many Faces of Power

The teacher character and the initial wish to keep a diary plant the seeds of a writerly perspective within the narrative. Their role is not simply to provide information, but to set the principal's administrative success against the need to write about personal experience. Writing and office both aspire to become vehicles of prestige, but they are subject to different ethical standards. The written record compels a confrontation with facts; the exercise of office permits convenient forgetting.

Influential figures such as Brindavan Babu and Balli Babu reveal two different manifestations of power. On the one hand are connections, proximity, discussion and symbolic recognition of standing; on the other is the practical world of office, elections, intervention, patronage and direct pressure. The principal sees both as useful to him and potentially directed against him. These characters do not remain merely portraits of wicked individuals; they become instruments for understanding institutional dependence.

Students repeatedly appear as groups. Their movements may raise genuine questions, but there is also the possibility of their being used by external

political forces. It would be mistaken to interpret this ambiguity as a straightforwardly anti-student position. Rather, the story asks how the independent voice of students is to be distinguished from the voices of representatives acting in their name. The narrative thus approaches the difficult subject of democracy within the university.

Usha Ji's appearance suggests the possibility of an alternative dialogue between women's intellectual presence in an institution and its male-dominated networks of power. Her own intellectual development, professional difficulties and independent decisions, however, receive limited elaboration. Consequently, the story illuminates the principal's transformation through her more than it illuminates her own self-directed life. Explicit recognition of this limitation forms part of a fair assessment of the work.

The Narrator, Language and the Movement of Satire

The narration of this long story continually moves between external description and the character's inward stream of thought. The narrator reports an incident and immediately enters the character's conjectures, apprehensions, sense of humiliation or self-justification. This allows readers both proximity to and distance from the principal's mind: they can accompany him while also recognising his self-deception. Satire here arises less through direct attacks upon a person than through the gap between his perspective and the actual situation.

Fragmented sentences, prolonged sequences of pauses, recurrent questions and the rhythm of self-correction are important linguistic features. Before one thought is completed, another anxiety intervenes. These broken and rejoined sentences express the principal's uncertainty. The reader's initial amusement later becomes unease, for what first appeared as a man's restless manner comes to signify his inner insecurity.

The prose occasionally enters the realm of conceptual discussion. Questions of religion, politics, teaching and social assumptions jostle with the principal's private concerns. The result is double-edged: conceptual richness on one side and an uneven tautness of narration on the other. Particularly when the story offers more sentences of argument than the enactment of events, the reader's progress may slow. Yet this looseness cannot be condemned without examination: it also arises from the character's overcrowded mental life.

Three Principal Symbols: The Diary, the College and the Caricatures

The diary changes its meaning between the opening and closing images. Initially, it embodies the dream of a document that will secure future fame. In the middle it witnesses the lack of time and the postponement of decisions. At the end it becomes a metaphor for the individual's inability to acknowledge himself, despite the accumulation of factual events. The man who supervises the public accounts of an educational community cannot produce a

trustworthy account of his own inner life. Herein lies the depth of the title's irony.

The college is expected to embody the ideals of education and independent thought. In the story, its expanding buildings signify progress, but various pressures quietly grow alongside them. This contrast suggests that physical construction and the ethical development of an institution are not synonymous. The issues of examinations, appointments, status and students' rights combine to make the college a map of power in the local community.

In the line-drawn caricatures published alongside the story, crown-like shapes, distorted faces and suggestive outlines of bodies do not reproduce events literally. They are visual signs of the desire for power and of awkward incongruity. Their contribution is to make readers view the principal's social office from a humorous distance. A comparison with illustrated children's stories is possible, but the functions differ: in a children's picture story, comprehension and recall may be primary; here satire and institutional criticism are the dominant purposes.

Educational Institutions and Politics: The Story's Social Critique

In the story's educational world, formal rules and actual decision-making power appear to operate separately. University offices, governing committees, teaching posts, examinations, assessment and campus voices all claim authority in determining procedures; political patronage, personal recommendations and fear nevertheless bend these very procedures. The writer presents this tension not in the language of an administrative report but through an individual's state of mind. Problems centred in power thereby become problems of private human instability as well.

The moral hesitation of an educated person is particularly significant in this story. On numerous occasions the principal knows what would be just for the institution, yet at the moment of decision he wavers over his future, his name and his employment. Without understanding this human weakness, the social critique remains incomplete. The real object of the writer's satire is not merely corruption but the mental strategies through which an educated person legitimises compromise by declaring it inevitable.

Student activism constitutes an important counterforce. Their presence prevents the college from remaining the principal's private possession and makes it a shared institution in which the right to raise questions is contested. Yet the narrative devotes comparatively little attention to the internal diversity of student movements. A fuller development of students' distinct individual voices could have given the critique of institutions a greater multiplicity of perspectives.

A Comparative Dialogue with the History of Maithili Children's Literature

Clarifying the Difference of Genre

To call ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’ a children's story or children's novel would mislead readers about its intended audience. The original publication identifies it as a long story, and its major concerns are university administration, political factionalism, an adult's self-deception, the pressures of office and complex social satire. It is not organised around children's ages, linguistic receptivity or the accessible adaptations characteristic of folktales. Accordingly, the comparison with children's literature is not a competition between two works of the same genre; it is a comparison between different arrangements of readership within one language.

Oral Tradition and the Foundations of Children's Literature

In issue 50 of Videha, Phoolchandra Jha ‘Praveen’ discusses the oral traditions of Maithili infant folklore, upbringing, play and amusement, and forms that transmit knowledge. This historical perspective makes clear that the principal current of children's literature is not confined to published didactic tales but is connected with the sounds of home and courtyard, games and collective memory. Kumar Pawan's work is not written as a direct heir to this sonic world of childhood folklore; it centres upon modern educational institutions and the crisis of adult judgment. Nevertheless, both are indirectly connected by the question of how society transmits its values to the next generation. (Phoolchandra Jha ‘Praveen’, 2010)

The Simplicity of Children's Folktales and the Complexities of Adult Satire

Dr Yoganand Jha emphasises the linguistic simplicity, short sentences, curiosity, oral narrative manner, accessible characterisation and generally clear outcomes of children's folktales; he also distinguishes long from short folktales. Judged by these criteria, Kumar Pawan's story takes the opposite direction. Here uncertainty outlasts resolution, the ethical meaning is not exhausted by a single reading, and the principal's mental entanglement is the work's strength. Length alone, therefore, does not define a long story for children: narrative purpose and the reader's cognitive involvement are also decisive. (Yoganand Jha, 2011)

The History of Picture Stories and the Work's Visual Humour

In discussing Preeti Thakur's contribution to Maithili illustrated stories for children, Durganand Mandal emphasises the visual recovery of folktales, the ingenuity of Gonu Jha and folk heroes. Against this background, the caricatures published with Kumar Pawan's story reveal another branch of the reading experience. Illustrations in children's picture stories may make the narrative sequence visually accessible; here they become pointed signals of authorial satire. This does not mean that the work becomes children's literature because it contains pictures; rather, the comparison provides an

opportunity to understand the social functions of images. (Durganand Mandal, 2012; original story, pp. 21, 24, 29–30)

Children's Theatre and Institutional Resistance

Ramesh Ranjan's Videha essay on children's drama is a useful reference for discussions of young readers' active participation and dramatic structure. In Kumar Pawan's long story, student agitation, dialogue, entrances and exits, and public allegations produce a dramatic effect, but the organisation of these scenes does not follow the readily comprehensible justice of children's theatre. Even resistance becomes ambiguous through propaganda and the calculations of power. For adult readers, such ambiguity creates an opportunity for critical reflection; younger children might need help interpreting the episodes. (Ramesh Ranjan, 2013; original story)

Contemporary Criticism of Children's Novels and Reader Agency

'Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra', published in Videha, discusses critical criteria such as child characters' agency, the rewriting of folktales, illustration and language, ethical appropriateness and the reader's age. Using this critical framework further clarifies the generic limits of 'The Blank Pages of a Diary'. The story is centred upon the adult principal's consciousness. Characters associated with students challenge it, but the students themselves do not become its main focalisers. Instead of a child-oriented narrative, we encounter a critique of adult failures within an institution centred upon young people. (Gajendra Thakur, 2026)

Potential Uses for Adolescent Readers

In guided reading discussions with older adolescents, the story could raise issues of institutional accountability, the investigation of rumours, examination integrity, student autonomy and freedom of expression. Such educational uses, however, do not establish the work as children's literature. Being useful in an educational context and being written for children are separate categories, a distinction literary history must preserve.

Major Achievements and Critical Limitations

The work's first achievement is its exposure of the ironies of social structure through personal instability. The college principal's dilemmas might have provided material for light comedy, but the writer connects them to institutional relations of power. Its second achievement is the metaphor of self-writing: if every event of life deserves recording yet the page remains empty, the question concerns not merely a lack of time but the capacity to acknowledge truth. Its third is the vivid presentation of hesitation through dialogue, conjecture, self-questioning and interrupted internal sentences.

The story's limitations lie partly in its breadth. The density of episodes involving administration, office, politics and student conflict sometimes draws readers away from the central metaphor of the diary. The principal is so dominant in the characterisation that students' and female characters' independent perspectives receive limited development. Various political figures

occasionally remain representative types; the conflict would have acquired further dimensions had their individual social and historical complexities been explored more fully.

Even so, the author takes the risk of portraying his principal neither as a thoroughgoing villain nor as an exemplary reformer. The uncertainty of the ending does not release the reader from the social questions raised. Literary achievement cannot be measured only by narrative discipline: when a work withholds the comfort of an easy moral judgment, that very discomfort can become its critical strength.

Conclusion: From the Impossibility of Writing to the Question of Self-Testimony

Kumar Pawan's 'The Blank Pages of a Diary' may be regarded as an important example of a tendency within the Maithili long story to express criticism of institutional reality through the perplexities of the human mind. In an effort to establish his credibility, the principal repeatedly turns to the institution, his office, personal connections, electoral alignments and social respect. Yet when he must offer concrete testimony about his own life, his confidence in words begins to falter. The final emptiness is not a flat declaration of defeat but an open question about a consciousness caught in society's arrangements of power.

In the history of Maithili literature, it is more appropriate to place the work among adult tales of social satire concerning educational institutions than to present it as an example of children's literature. Comparative study of children's literature provides criteria for establishing its location: suitability for children, children's agency, narrative accessibility, visual language and the form of ethical judgment all distinguish it. Precisely because of these differences, the work has the capacity to generate serious dialogue among teachers, readers, students and literary critics about responsibility, power and authorial truth.

PART III

The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal

The Proverb, Social Prestige and Narrative Satire

Inside the Work

Kumar Pawan's 'The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal' is a narrative satire that uses the search for the meaning of an ordinary proverb to expose contradictions among meaning, value, prestige and success in modern Maithili society. In the extended episodes of this work, published in Sankalp, a first-person narrator addresses readers directly, converses with Bhuvan Kaka, pursues his fantasies and aspirations, and encounters different forms of institutional prestige. The inversion of value between the 'gold coin' and

'charcoal' is not confined to a single fixed explanation throughout the tale; it takes on fresh significance in each new situation. This essay presents separate close readings of all eight narrative episodes and examines the narrator's self-satire, dialogic method, subject and technique, the ironies of educational institutions, moral uncertainty and the open ending. It also considers the work's historical position in comparison with Harimohan Jha's tradition of humour and satire and later Maithili satirical writing. The conclusion is that the work transforms the accessible humour of everyday speech into a critical investigation of intellectual and social prestige, although its expansive episodic structure and locally specific allusions also require readers to participate actively in making meaning.

Introduction: Entering the Story through a Proverb

A popular saying is distinctive because it condenses the density of social experience into a brief phrase. When such a saying becomes the title of a narrative, its meaning no longer resides solely in a dictionary definition; the story tests what it implies. Kumar Pawan's 'The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal' makes this process its narrative foundation. The unequal worth of a gold coin and ordinary charcoal establishes a prior assumption about judgments of value. But the narrator does not stop there. He continues to search for the proverb's meaning through one episode after another, and with every explanation, meaning itself becomes less stable.

The work opens by addressing the reader directly. The narrator poses questions, imagines possible answers and then overturns them himself. Readers are not passive listeners but unacknowledged participants in the argument. Through this dialogic method, the text becomes less an event-driven story than a movement among experience, imagination, self-mockery and social irony. A superficial reading might take it as an amusing account of the search for a proverb's meaning; closer attention brings forth the anxiety of acquiring social prestige and the displacement of values as its central concerns.

Narrative Structure: Question, Episode and Renewed Question

The narrator first introduces a proverb whose precise import he does not understand. Seeking an answer, he turns to the experienced Bhuvan Kaka. Kaka's words are grounded in practical knowledge, but their exchange does not dispel the narrator's dissatisfaction. From this point the narrative flows through many episodes. The narrator moves among imagined versions of his life, possible meetings with eminent people, intellectual honours, social advancement and extraordinary plans for the future. His language reveals, by turns, confidence, a sense of inferiority, a longing for praise and the courage to refuse.

In the middle passages, dreams of miraculous experiences, visions of great figures, the company of distinguished people and unexpected gains carry the narrator in different directions. There is no single chain of cause and effect of the kind found in conventional plots. Every new fantasy comments on its

predecessor and adds another irony. When professorship, universities, research degrees, employment and recommendations enter the narrative, what appeared on the surface to concern personal advancement becomes a question about the machinery of intellectual and social prestige. In the concluding passages, questionable routes to material gain, influential contacts and difficult choices for securing privileges also emerge. Success and morality now confront each other as alternatives.

The ending returns the opening question to the reader. Through this final inquiry, interpretation of the opening proverb once again depends upon the reader's judgment. This circular arrangement is among the story's chief formal achievements. The point of the satire is not sealed within the last sentence; thought remains open even after the text ends.

Narrative Expansion and the Construction of Episodes

Addressing the Reader, the Title and the Initial Conflict over Value

The subtitle 'narrative satire' attached to the title provides an indication of how the work invites critical reception. The opening address, 'Dear readers', speaks directly to the audience: rather than seating readers on a high bench of judgment, the writer installs them as fellow thinkers. The proverbial phrase 'the plunder of gold coins and a mark on charcoal' remains the organising axis. The coin is valuable, charcoal comparatively commonplace; the words 'plunder' and 'mark' suggest different registers of action and signification. The question is why people abandon what is valuable and become fixed upon a merely nominal gain. Yet the narrative does not accept even this initial explanation as indisputable truth.

The narrator's intimate speech, interrogative grammar and proverb derived from lived experience operate together. Bhuvan Kaka enters as an embodiment of popular wisdom. The address 'Kaka' conveys both familial intimacy and the authority of an elder. The narrator is not ashamed to acknowledge his own inability to understand; this confession plants the seed of humour. Beyond the pursuit of a valuable object, the purpose for which it would be used also comes under examination. The episode thus establishes a twofold question: what does the proverb mean, and who determines the meaning of 'value' in life?

Bhuvan Kaka and the Incomplete Answer of Folk Wisdom

In the second episode, the narrator's conversation with Bhuvan Kaka develops further. He appeals to an elder's experience to understand the saying, but experience does not provide a simple and exhaustive definition. Kaka's response, together with the narrator's further curiosity, creates a significant tension within social knowledge. Kaka is not merely a teacher or moral instructor: through his address to Kaka, the narrator increasingly exposes his own inconsistencies.

Common measures by which people assess 'worth'—prominent individuals, office, honour, name, fame, high and low rank—enter the satire. The

economic value of an object and the symbolic value of prestige are not identical, but social conduct frequently converts one into the other. The characters' exchanges reveal this confusion. The prose advances through continuous questions and counter-questions. Instead of lengthy expository passages, the lively rhythm of dialogue propels the narrative.

The Expansion of Fantasy and the Testing of Self-Infatuation

In this episode, the narrator's attention turns towards meeting extraordinarily important people, unexpected achievements and his possible future. The writer uses visions of great figures and the idea of 'darshan', or privileged sight, satirically. The more extravagant the narrator's dreams of an exceptional future become, the more clearly his present incapacity emerges. Humour consequently falls not only upon the other characters but upon the narrator himself. This self-satire prevents the narrative from becoming merely a mockery of others.

The scenes change continuously. These shifting mental pictures require readers to distinguish actual encounters, imagined incidents and images of the narrator's aspiration. In that sense the episode concerns mental time more than the story's external time. Every leap of fantasy examines another measure of social success. A distance emerges between the desire to become 'great' and the true ethical significance of greatness.

The Language of Honour and the Performance of Rank

The narrator's aspirations here assume a more explicitly social form. A form of address such as 'Professor Sahib' is not merely a term of respect; it points to a collective imagination of office and influence. The possibilities of satire increase when intellectual authority is derived not from the quality of thought but from the glamour of a particular position. The narrator pictures himself in a world where education and prestige are taken to support each other, while the hope of advantage remains attached to both.

Exaggerated self-imagining distinguishes the episode. A slight incident in everyday life becomes a grand social scene in the narrator's mind. The posture of humility and the intensity of desire become entangled in his speech. This contradiction makes readers laugh, but the laughter carries a critical edge: how often is our public respect for office really respect for the potential advantages it may bring?

Social Mobility, Relationships and the Shadow of Self-Interest

Meetings with acquaintances, memories of the village and comparisons of one's own social situation become important here. People recognise each other through earlier acquaintance, yet forms of address and behaviour may change as social position changes. The narrator is acutely sensitive to these distinctions. His mental responses reveal the many ways in which an absence of rank, wealth and connections can produce feelings of inferiority and the desire for self-display.

Several conversations end in half-statements, and responses are often immediate and emotional. The narrator is thereby rendered less than wholly reliable as a thinker. Readers weigh his statements against his desires. This is a subtle device of satire: the author's critical perspective may stand apart from what the narrator himself accepts. Dreams of social advancement can thus be read here as psychological pressures rather than objective achievements.

A Professor's Salary, Institutions and Intellectual Capital

The mention of a 'professor's salary' explicitly connects the narrative with academic and institutional life. The university, teaching, research, examining and degrees open up a world in which the social uses of knowledge are tied to opportunities for a livelihood. The work does not ridicule the pursuit of knowledge; it examines the tendency to acquire prestige, opportunities or favour in knowledge's name.

Alongside the desire for office comes the objective question of 'work'. Wanting a title and making the effort to acquire the competence it requires are not the same. The narrator's lack of preparation turns this distinction into a source of humour. Short questions, immediate answers and abrupt reversals of conclusions prevent the discussion of institutions from becoming a didactic essay. Social critique is absorbed into narrative and laughter. This episode may be regarded as a central link in the work's institutional satire.

Opportunism, Recommendations and the Conflict over Self-Respect

Here the narrator once again looks towards his acquaintances, former relationships and possible assistance in advancing socially. References to powerful people, recommendations, employment and advantages sharpen the question of whether success should be regarded as the fruit of one's own labour or of personal connections. His dreams continually change; his decisions show little stability and a strong attraction towards opportunity. The writer exposes this uncertainty more through unexpected turns of events than through explicit moral commentary.

Importantly, the work is not simply a portrayal of one individual's greed. Social structure itself makes proximity to people in office a means of advantage. The narrator's weakness is partly a product of that structure. Yet the work does not absolve him entirely: it repeatedly attacks his self-deception. This two-sided criticism of opportunism allows readers to examine both the individual and the institution.

Moral Boundaries and a Question Returned to the Reader

In this episode, the narrator encounters discussion of possibilities resembling illicit smuggling. Rather than treating the passage as a literal chronicle of events, it is more appropriate to understand it as a satirical limit-case of the excessive temptation to choose 'any road at all' towards social advancement. Success, which earlier appeared in the guise of honour, now turns into a question of moral deterioration. The narrator also disagrees with this option; his character is therefore not that of a uniformly opportunistic person but one filled with conflicting desires.

In closing, the narrator again addresses his readers and asks, 'Well, do any of you know another meaning?' The opening proverb returns not as a closed door of explanation but as an open question. Having searched for its meaning throughout the narrative, he leaves the adequate answer to the judgment of the reader. This openness secures the reader's critical role. The final instalment identifies the writer's affiliation as the Department of Hindi, Jagdamba Mahila College, Laheriasarai; it would not, however, be appropriate to infer any further biographical details from this information.

Narrative Technique and the Multiple Layers of Meaning

The Proverb as an Instrument of Meaning, Not a Plot

A proverb is usually a brief conclusion drawn from the complexities of life. The writer, however, does not accept its meaning as predetermined. The gold coin and charcoal become images of different kinds of value. In some episodes, the 'gold coin' appears to stand for economic gain; in others, prestige or a prudent decision. A 'mark on charcoal' may suggest remaining satisfied with a small achievement, wasted effort or fascination with a meaningless external sign. Yet all these are analytical possibilities: the text never definitively establishes any single interpretation. Without this caution, the open significance of the satire would be reduced to a slogan.

The return of the proverb maintains coherence in the flow of the narrative. Episodes change, but the question does not. Consequently, even where the work appears loosely expansive, its structural centre remains stable. The saying serves as a touchstone against which social incidents are repeatedly tested.

The Unreliability of 'I' and Self-Satire

The first-person narrator occupies a position of apparent authority over knowledge while exposing his own confusion. Readers understand his aspirations as well as his words. The more he imagines himself becoming important, the more his inner contradictions are revealed. The target of satire is not merely an 'other' but the narrating 'I' himself. Readers laugh with him and at him, and ultimately reflect upon their own social habits.

Many of the narrator's ideas change immediately. This instability cannot be called merely a fault of character; it gives narrative expression to the ironies of social life. The same person may regard himself as self-respecting and yet crave proximity to the powerful. This inner contradiction underlies the work's credible social psychology.

Dialogism: Reader, Kaka and the Language of Institutions

At least three levels of voice can be heard in the work: the narrator addressing readers; Bhuvan Kaka's language grounded in experience; and the formal vocabulary associated with the world of office and prestige. Differences among these voices generate satire. When intimate forms of address in everyday life encounter terms such as 'professor', 'lecturer', 'university' and 'degree', language becomes a map of society's hierarchies. Rather than preach, the writer places unequal voices face to face.

This arrangement of dialogue does not command readers simply to accept the storyteller's conclusions. Several points of view appear, and readers must decide when the narrator is right, when he is deluded and when he makes himself the object of ridicule.

Humour, Irony and the Inversion of Meaning

The first level of humour is simply linguistic: a short contradiction after a long fantasy, a reversed answer following a question, and sudden reality after exaggeration. The second is social: society readily bows before the name of an office but seldom examines the competence actually required for it or its purpose. The third is ethical: a person eager for success briefly encounters a path on which success and morality oppose each other. Across all three levels, the metaphor of the ‘gold coin’ continually assumes new meanings.

The sharpness of the writer's satire lies not in a plain negation of facts but in a rearrangement of incongruous situations. An unnatural fantasy becomes humorous when it exposes socially accepted assumptions from within. Ostentation, flattery and eagerness for profit thereby become subjects of scrutiny.

The Work's Limitations and Critical Objections

Alongside the work's effects are certain limitations. Because the narrator's fantasies expand more widely than the action, the pace slows in some episodes. Several comic allusions depend upon knowledge of local social relationships and institutional terminology of their period; their immediate resonance may be weaker for contemporary readers. The story opens many possibilities but does not develop all the episodes with equal seriousness. Some passages may therefore seem like independent fragments of jest.

Nevertheless, it would be equally mistaken to regard this dispersion solely as a defect. The narrator's uncontrolled movement of thought itself reveals the lack of control in social aspiration. Readers must therefore ask how much of the looseness is deliberate and how much belongs to the work's construction. A fair critical position recognises both possibilities.

A Comparative Place in Maithili Literary History

From Folk Humour to Modern Narrative Satire

One source of the humorous tradition in Maithili prose lies in popular sayings, farce, conversation and contradictions in social conduct. Kumar Pawan's work draws energy from this source by investigating the meaning of a proverb. Its concern, however, is not limited to conventional customs or the comedy of domestic life; it also engages with office-seeking among the educated, prestige arising from university procedures and the desire for modern conveniences. In this sense, the proverb becomes an instrument for examining modern institutional life.

The tradition of farce exemplified by Jyotirishwar's ‘Dhurta Samagama’ and the history of dissenting laughter in the vernacular are worth recalling. Yet it

would be mistaken to declare this work a direct descendant without examining differences in historical period, literary form and purpose. The social characters of an older farce and the psychological portrait of a first-person satirist here belong to distinct genres. The proper basis of comparison is their shared ability to make contradictions visible through laughter, not an unverified claim of historical influence.

Harimohan Jha's 'Khattar Kakak Tarang' and Kumar Pawan

In discussions of modern Maithili humour and satire, Harimohan Jha's 'Khattar Kakak Tarang' (1948) provides a useful point of comparison. Videha's author profile also lists his 'Kanyadan' (1933) and other works alongside this satire. Kumar Pawan's writing enters into dialogue with the well-known tradition of reasoning humour in 'Khattar Kakak Tarang' in that questioning established assumptions through laughter is important to both. Their structures of address, however, differ. Harimohan Jha's celebrated Khattar Kaka becomes a powerful centre of thought through dialogue; in Kumar Pawan's story, the questioning centre is the narrator himself, a man beset by doubt who loses an earlier assumption with every new episode.

This comparison does not establish the 'influence' of either work on the other. Doing so would require manuscript evidence, statements by the author, successive publication records or direct intertextual evidence. Available materials permit discussion only of generic affinity and differences of technique. Such critical restraint prevents literary history from becoming a genealogy of praise.

Later Maithili Satire and Generic Continuity

Videha's book catalogue lists Ashok's 'Neek Dinak Bioscope' (a collection of satire, 2018) and 'Katha-Path' (a critical study of Maithili stories, 2022). These entries establish only that satire and story criticism also continue as independent works in later Maithili writing. Bibliographic listings alone do not justify claims about the contents, technique or direct relationship of these books to Kumar Pawan. Nevertheless, placing the narrative satire from issue 5/68 alongside these records makes clear the need to study periodical satire and book-length satire in parallel.

Kumar Pawan's 'Paith' and 'The Blank Pages of a Diary' are also listed in Videha's catalogue. These entries provide information about the existence of other prose works by the author; they do not, by themselves, warrant conclusions about the chronology of his entire literary career or the development of his narrative methods. Direct comparison with his other published writings remains a subject for more firmly grounded future research.

Re-reading Literary History: The Importance of a 'Small' Work

Literary histories often construct accounts of literary tendencies around book-length collections, prize-winning works and established writers. A narrative satire consisting of eight episodes scattered across a magazine exposes the limitations of such a history. This work gives readers a small but

concentrated record of the complex relationships among everyday language, educational institutions, social opportunism and moral judgment. Only when literary history accommodates such close readings of periodical texts can the many-sided social role of humour and satire become clear.

This study proposes documentary discipline, not extravagant evaluative claims. No textual evidence is available for proclaiming this one story the first or the greatest example of Maithili satire. The grounds for calling it distinctive are more carefully delimited: an inquiry into meaning driven by a proverb; a self-contradictory narrator; satire of social institutions; and an open ending that transfers the question to the reader. Its place in literary history should be determined by these verifiable characteristics.

Conclusion

Kumar Pawan's 'The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal' is a narrative satire that begins with a small question about meaning and proceeds towards the large contradictions of modern society. The symbolic opposition between the high value of gold coins and the ordinariness of charcoal is not merely a comparison of objects. It brings under scrutiny the criteria by which educated society judges 'greatness', material comfort, prestigious office, claims to competence and moral decisions. The narrator appears before readers with both his ego and insecurities; Bhuvan Kaka introduces a dimension of folk wisdom; and the institutional world reveals the distance between success and knowledge.

The work's most effective device is its questioning method. In the search for one meaning, the narrator opens numerous interpretive possibilities and ultimately makes the reader the judge. This openness, combined with self-satire and social humour, makes the work worthy of attention in the study of modern Maithili prose. Even allowing for some looseness of episodic structure and difficulties arising from references specific to an earlier period, the story provides a pointed critique of the inversion of values. It is therefore more appropriate to read this brief work not simply as a humorous sketch but as a multilayered investigation of society's system of values.

PART IV

Paith, Memory and Self-Writing

A Literary-Theoretical Comparison of "Paith" and "The Blank Pages of a Diary"

A Writer's Literary Identity through a Single Story

In literary history, a single work sometimes comes to represent the entire name of its author. Despite Chandradhar Sharma Guleri's other literary contributions, 'Usne Kaha Tha' remains the famous story most closely associated with him. It is in this sense that the comparison is employed when

‘Paith’ is regarded as a representative work of Kumar Pawan's literary identity. This is neither a claim that the two stories share the same subject nor an attempt to establish similarities of narrative technique, characters, endings or sensibility. A single story can bring a writer widespread recognition: that alone is the purpose of the comparison.

Such recognition requires a qualification. The central place of one work in readers' memory does not mean that an author's other writings are secondary or without value. A study of Kumar Pawan's ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’ and ‘The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal’ makes it clear that his narrative vision extends beyond the communal feast to educational institutions, self-examination and the ironies of social prestige. ‘Paith’ may be the work through which a writer is recognised, but an understanding of the whole writer requires attention to the broader body of work.

Heavenly Admission and the Emptiness of Self-Writing: Two Contradictions

The primary sense of ‘Paith’ is linked to the popular religious belief that the departed soul should find a place or acceptance in heaven. The story's ethical irony, however, lies in the fact that Kaniya Kaki's modest request for food for her daughter's son caused rejection and uproar during her lifetime, while a grand feast was arranged after her death to secure her heavenly admission. The title thus exposes the contradiction between acceptance in the next world and neglect in this one. The rows of diners and public prestige are accompanying images of this fundamental opposition, not the primary meaning of ‘paith’ itself.

‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’ contains a different kind of emptiness. Rather than the posthumous acceptance of a dead soul, it concerns the self-testimony of a living person. The diary's pages stand open to be written upon, yet the principal cannot produce a decisive record of his experiences. One story reveals the gulf between public ritual for a soul after death and neglect in life; the other exposes the distance between a living official's public image and private truth. In both, the discrepancy between professed ideals and actual conduct generates satire.

In ‘Paith’, collective attention is devoted to religious acceptance in the afterlife, while Kaniya Kaki's small request in life goes unheard. In ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’, a person receives social recognition through office but cannot write the truth of his private life. The first story asks why a society eager to gain heavenly admission for a departed soul fails to discharge its duties towards a person in life; the second asks why someone with authority cannot write an honest account of experience. The comparison preserves the distinct forms of public ritual and private self-writing while identifying a common ethical distance.

Narrative Time: Recollection, Present Experience and an Unfinished Future

Narrative time is not simply the orderly progression of a clock. Memory, apprehension and expectation change its flow. In 'Paith', the present of the funeral feast is joined by Kaniya Kaki's humiliation in life, her request for food for her daughter's son, Gunja's situation and the uncertain possibilities of the family's future. Through this movement back and forth, the arrangements intended to secure the soul's admission to heaven can no longer be detached from the ethical account of the life that preceded them. Memory brings a human face and an unheard appeal out from behind the crowd.

Time is stranger still in 'The Blank Pages of a Diary'. A diary usually transforms moments that have passed into a written present. But the principal's life is so occupied with plans, apprehensions and calculations concerning his position and prestige on the following day that passing moments cannot enter the record. Anxiety about the future consumes the experience of the present, leaving the evidence of the past blank. This is not merely a narrative contrivance but a satire upon the experience of time in a life entangled with power.

The return of time takes different forms in the two long stories. In 'Paith', Kaniya Kaki's suffering in life tests the claims of the feast performed after her death. In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', the busyness of the present obstructs the production of a reliable record of the past. Memory of life questions the ritual present in the first work; the written location of memory remains empty in the second. In both, what matters more than chronology is the way people treat their lived experience.

Narratorial Distance and the Ethics of Point of View

In 'Paith', the crowd, funeral observances, memories of Kaniya Kaki's life and contradictory voices together constitute the narrative scene. No single perspective can become the truth of the entire village. The controversy arising from her simple request for food leads readers away from the community's outward religious performance and towards the wound within the family. In this multiperspectival composition, readers must construct meaning while attending to what characters know and to the limits of that knowledge. When the narrative does not declare a definitive judgment, the silence also creates an opportunity for the reader's ethical participation.

In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', the gap between the principal's self-justifications and the public consequences of his behaviour is the principal ground of satire. Behind decisions he regards as reasonable may lie the need to protect his office, fear of failure and the advantages of close relationships. The narrative is arranged so that his insecurity remains visible to readers even when the principal himself cannot grasp its complete significance.

The politics of point of view matters in both works. 'Paith' asks who will tell the story of someone whose voice is drowned out by the collective. 'The

Blank Pages of a Diary' asks what someone who possesses the power to write will record and what he will evade. Literary perspective is here a distribution of knowledge: author, character and reader do not all know the same thing in the same way.

The Funeral Feast and the College: Testing the Values of Social Institutions

A funeral feast and a college appear outwardly to be unrelated institutions. One is a communal undertaking associated with popular religious belief; the other a formal centre of modern education. Yet prestige, relationships, rank and collective approval influence both. 'Paith' asks why a modest appeal made during Kaniya Kaki's lifetime caused an uproar while the feast after her death won assent. 'The Blank Pages of a Diary' asks how office, recommendations and patronage affect the declared ideals of education. These different social processes provide grounds for an ethical comparison.

In 'Paith', the distribution of food is not only a question of grain but also of timing and purpose: resistance to a little food requested for the living daughter's son and abundance at a feast intended to gain admission for the dead soul. On the other hand, the value of knowledge in the principal's institution is surrounded by official credentials, political patronage and public image. Critical concepts of social capital and symbolic prestige are useful here; nonetheless, the specific religious significance of the popular belief surrounding the dead should not be reduced entirely to calculations of reputation.

It would be mistaken to dissolve both narratives into a single social formula. The crisis of 'Paith' consists in the acute opposition between the hunger of the living, contempt for maternal affection and ritual for the dead soul's heavenly admission; the crisis of the college is the prolonged erosion of rules, office and judgment. In one, the ethical inconsistency is visible in a little grain set against a huge feast after death; in the other, it appears in the language of decisions and the use of authority. A comparison that preserves this difference respects the distinctive visions of the stories.

Women's Experiences and the Invisible Account of Private Life

In 'Paith', Kaniya Kaki's suffering changes the meaning of the funeral feast from within. The uproar over her modest request for food while alive sharpens the questions of affection and family responsibility. The elaborate arrangements for her soul's admission to heaven after death constitute the ethical inversion of that neglect. Gunja's presence further intensifies the issues of inheritance and women's position in society.

In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', institutional power occupies the centre of the principal's thoughts. The appearance of female characters occasionally opens the possibility of self-correction for the male protagonist, but their own lives do not receive full development. This is also a significant limitation of the work. On the one hand, women assist the man's introspection; on the

other, the reader may ask, precisely because they occupy this supporting role, where their independent struggles are to be found.

An important question in comparing these stories is whose experience literature makes its ethical centre. Amid the collective feast undertaken for the welfare of the dead in the next world, 'Paith' gives voice to Kaniya Kaki's ignored wish while alive. 'The Blank Pages of a Diary' reveals the self-absorbed limitations of a man's institutional life. Between these two representations lies an opportunity to reconsider gender perspectives and social responsibility in Maithili fiction.

The Triangle of Humour, Compassion and Irony

An important characteristic of Kumar Pawan's satire is that humour ultimately becomes an uncomfortable experience. In 'Paith', arguments about the enormous funeral feast, the rushing about and the social postures initially provide opportunities for amusement. But this laughter becomes serious when the contrast comes into view between the dispute over Kaniya Kaki's modest request for food in life and the lavish arrangements for heavenly admission after her death. The storyteller does not merely wish readers to laugh at social incongruities; he makes them reflect upon why they are laughing.

In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', the principal's self-justifications, fascination with office, fear of possible criticism and the complicated play of external patronage produce humour. Within that humour, however, lies a crisis of trust in educational institutions. Alongside their laughter, readers are led to ask how the ethical basis of institutional decisions has been eroded.

Compassion and humour are not opposed emotions in either story. In 'Paith', irony assumes a compassionate meaning when Kaniya Kaki's neglect in life confronts the feast for her heavenly admission after death. In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', the distance between the college's authority and the principal's inward apprehensions creates insecurity alongside laughter. This compassion lifts readers beyond immediate emotion and compels them to think about justice, responsibility and the human significance of institutions.

Illustrations, Images and Visual Memory

The presence of line drawings in the published forms of 'Paith' and 'The Blank Pages of a Diary' supports the stories' emotional worlds. Eyes, faces, bodily figures and crown-like images sometimes raise questions about the right to see and at other times become satirical signs of the aspiration to power. To dismiss the illustrations as mere ornament would be to overlook an important dimension of the reading experience.

The effect of visual suggestions is also connected with the methods of the prose. In 'Paith', the crowd, dining rows and window at the funeral feast distinguish the outward ritual from the different world of memories of Kaniya Kaki's life. In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', the office, college and frustrated desire to write organise the field of vision. The first asks why the suffering of

the living was not seen; the second asks why what was seen was not written. This relation increases the symbolic force of the titles.

Open Endings and the Responsibility of the Reader

The ending of a story need not merely terminate events; it may initiate meaning anew. In ‘Paith’, even after the feast intended to gain admission for Kaniya Kaki's soul has concluded, the ethical debt incurred by the dispute over food for her daughter's son during her life remains outstanding. The grand ritual's claims confront the actual treatment of a living person. The memory of this conflict stays with the reader.

In ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’, the principal fails to prepare an honest account of his life. At the end, the title becomes significant once again: the more experiences accumulate, the greater grows the ethical difficulty of writing them down. The final emptiness transforms the character's failure into a question for readers: when and how do we give a private account of our public decisions?

The ending of ‘Paith’ leaves readers remembering unfinished social obligations towards Kaniya Kaki during her lifetime rather than merely the completion of the funeral feast. In ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’, the emptiness of self-writing becomes the ethical outcome of the principal's struggles. In the former, neglect in life stands against rituals focused on acceptance in the afterlife; in the latter, an absence of self-testimony stands against public authority. Both challenge readers to construct their own final ethical judgments.

Narrative Polyphony and Social Language

Society's language is not uniform. In ‘Paith’, the reactions of organisers, invited guests, neglected individuals, family members and the crowd arise from different conditions of life. In this plurality of voices, the writer's single judgment does not automatically occupy the centre. The tensions among social voices remain before the reader.

In ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’, the languages of command, assurance, rumour, accusation, patronage and private doubt cut across one another. The encounter between administrative terminology and personal fear energises the irony. Institutional dialogue becomes not an indisputable record of truth but a means of defending office and balancing power.

Neither story is a dry illustration of linguistics; both are imaginative representations of conflicts within life. Which experiences social language grants prestige to and which it pushes aside are continuously expressed in scenes and dialogues. The flexibility of the Maithili vernacular keeps this plurality alive.

Symbolic Capital, Hunger and Morality

Prestige may assume the form of a title, an invitation, a seat of honour or proximity to an influential person. In ‘Paith’, the huge feast for the departed soul's admission to heaven also becomes an expression of social prestige, but the controversy over a little food requested for Kaniya Kaki's daughter's son during her lifetime exposes the limits of its value. In ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’, the institution becomes caught in the symbolic brilliance of office instead of its stated educational purpose.

The contradiction is that institutions held in public honour—the religious feast after death and the educational institution—can both offer opportunities to protect human dignity and become sites of its devaluation. Kumar Pawan reveals the distance between reverence for religious ritual and human obligations towards the living; in the other story he reveals the distance between educational prestige and moral truth. Neither system can be dissolved into a one-dimensional lesson.

Morality here is not merely a matter of personal virtue. The distance between the duty to provide a little food for Kaniya Kaki's daughter's son while she lived and the social desire to hold a feast for her soul's admission after death demands ethical scrutiny. Similarly, just decisions within education are a public duty. This broader meaning of morality gives both works enduring social importance.

The Limits of Similarity and the Independent Achievements of the Works

The metaphor of the dead soul's admission to heaven in ‘Paith’ does not reappear unchanged in ‘The Blank Pages of a Diary’. The first story establishes several centres in ritual, community and family; the second gives prominence to the distressed inner world of an ambitious individual within an institution. The first concerns the hunger of the living, affection, death and the hope of an afterlife; the second concerns office, publicity, rules and self-writing. Simply calling both ‘social satire’ would efface these differences.

Nevertheless, the suggestiveness of their titles, unanswered questions, fascination with public image and concern for human dignity link them through a common narrative vision. The more extensive the social scene becomes, the more inward the story's ethical questions turn. In ‘Paith’, the conflict between Kaniya Kaki's modest need for grain during life and the feast for her heavenly admission after death, and in the other work, the principal's inability to write the truth, are distinct crises that nevertheless make readers value deeds above declarations.

The importance of ‘Paith’ as a representative work lies in its distinctive Maithili social world, Kaniya Kaki's experience as a woman, the neglect she suffers in life, the irony of the funeral feast and the open ethical question. One story can establish an author's public identity, but an assessment of his work must not confine him to a single composition. Read beside ‘The Blank Pages

of a Diary' and other writings, Kumar Pawan's social critique becomes more fully comprehensible. His literary achievement lies not in imitating another storyteller but in transforming the inner contradictions of his own society into narrative art.

Synthesis: The Shared Structures of Narrative Practice

The critical study of all three works makes clear that the distance between outward behaviour and inward intention is a recurring concern in Kumar Pawan's fictional world. In 'Paith', a demand for a little grain for Kaniya Kaki's daughter's son causes uproar while she lives, whereas a huge feast is held for heavenly admission after her death. In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', educational prestige stands beside an emptiness of self-testimony. In 'The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal', the apparent wisdom of a proverb confronts the irony of society's hunger for rank. In different circumstances, all three raise the same question: how does society actually practise the values it professes?

In 'Paith', the fragmented voices of the communal funeral feast meet memories of Kaniya Kaki's humiliation and affection during life. In 'The Blank Pages of a Diary', administrative success and insecure self-consciousness expose each other. In 'The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal', the process of searching for a proverb's meaning unsettles readers' own judgments of value. Each of these techniques has a different rhythm: communal satire generated by the clash between ritual and life; institutional psychological satire; and direct address to the reader.

The creative success of the satire resides not solely in the sharpness of laughter but also in the presence of compassion. Confronted with disorder in social relationships, readers do not receive the simple satisfaction of locating someone to blame. They must also reflect upon their own conduct, their conceptions of honour and the part played by silence. In modern Maithili fiction, such a critically engaged readership may be regarded as a distinctive contribution of Kumar Pawan's narrative writing.

The works have limitations as well. Certain extended episodes slow the narratives; some characters, particularly in the representation of women's independent experiences, call for fuller development. Nevertheless, the originality of these works remains intact: 'Paith', 'The Blank Pages of a Diary' and 'The Plunder of Gold Coins and a Mark on Charcoal' all give literary expression to major questions confronting society.

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STUDY 07 / NIT NAVAL

Ashish Anchinhar

PART I

Editing, Literary Memory, and Plural Histories

Rereading Maithili Literature

REVIEW 1

THE COMPLETE WORKS OF NABONARAYAN MISHRA

The Confluence of Literature, Cultural Activism, and Memory

Book under review: Nabonarayan Mishra Samagra (The Complete Works of Nabonarayan Mishra) · Edited by Ashish Anchinhar · 2026

Abstract

The literature of Nabonarayan Mishra cannot be understood within the boundaries of a single genre. In his creative world, interviews, institutional history, literary portraits, memoirs, stories, satire, festive songs, elegies, and poetry advocating linguistic rights enter into dialogue with one another. Edited by Ashish Anchinhar, Nabonarayan Mishra Samagra brings these dispersed writings together and makes visible the labour-intensive foundations of modern Maithili literature—foundations that cannot be apprehended merely by counting celebrated authors, awards, and separately published books. The collection is particularly significant for its documentation of the Maithili movement in Kolkata, literary magazines, cultural organisations, and the theatrical activities of Kokil Manch.

This study examines the collection's interviews, essays, fiction, and verse separately. The interviews offer living testimony to the movement for linguistic rights; the essays preserve institutional memory; the stories explore family relationships, dowry, philanthropy, migration, and moral irony; and the poems give voice to communal consciousness and personal injury. Its literary achievements are accompanied by limitations: idealistic resolutions sometimes diminish a story's complexity; eulogistic portraits sometimes weaken critical distance; and poetry sometimes becomes subordinate to explicit pronouncement. Nevertheless, the collection is an important primary text for considering the social foundations of literature, the labour of the stage, and historical memory.

Keywords: Nabonarayan Mishra; Ashish Anchinhar; Maithili prose; Kolkata; Kokil Manch; interviews; Maithili movement; folk memory; Maithili fiction; literary history.

Introduction: The Question of Invisible Labour in Literary History

Literary histories are commonly organised around authors' names, lists of published works, literary movements, and the succession of awards. Yet the life of a language and its literature resides not only in literary texts but also in the society that makes those texts possible. Someone books the auditorium, builds the stage, brings the performers together, delivers invitations, preserves handwritten material, recruits subscribers to magazines, and takes to the streets in a movement. Without acknowledging such contributions, any account of the circulation of literature remains incomplete. Nabonarayan Mishra's writing constitutes a historical presence of precisely this invisible labour.

Nabonarayan Mishra was not merely a storyteller or poet; he was a participant in Maithili public life, a writer of lived experience, and a witness to cultural activity. The editor's introduction makes clear that his first published work appeared in 1977, while his writings, separated by decades, were brought together in 2026. This long interval is not, by itself, definitive proof of his literary neglect. It does, however, compel us to ask which writers the institutional resources of publication and the distribution of recognition have made visible.

The term samagra, or "complete works," in the title should not be read as a literal claim to absolute completeness. It is better understood as an attempt to preserve historically the material that could be recovered. The editor himself indicates that the chronology of the writings, publication details, and their availability are uneven, and that further material may be added. This candid admission does not diminish the book's importance; instead, it clarifies the complexities of its textual history.

The Structure of the Writings and the Critical Perspective

The collection comprises three interviews, fifteen essays, eleven stories, and nineteen works in verse. Within this fourfold structure, the interviews present historical voices, the essays provide memoiristic and institutional interpretation, the stories depict social circumstances, and the poems articulate emotion and dissent. Despite their generic diversity, the works share an underlying thread: loyalty to the Maithili language, mutual responsibility within a community, and an ethical examination of human conduct.

Three levels of analysis are useful here. The first concerns the relationship between subject matter, scene, character, and form within each work; the second, the expression of similar themes across different genres; and the third, comparison with the conventional model of Maithili literary history in which eminent authors occupy centre stage while the organisers of literary activity

remain marginal. Keeping these levels distinct prevents the collection's literary and historical values from collapsing into each other.

Interviews: Oral History and the Linguistic Public Sphere

The three interviewees are, respectively, Kishorikant Mishra, Ramlochan Thakur, and Dr Virendra Mallik. Because the material takes the form of questions and answers, it is not a record of the author's solitary reflections but a polyphonic document emerging through conversation. The interviewer's choices of subject are themselves significant: arrival in Kolkata, institutions, editing, theatre, movements, magazines, younger generations, linguistic rights, and personal experience. These themes reveal Nabonarayan Mishra's cultural priorities.

A Conversation with Kishorikant Mishra: Language, Education, and Print Culture

In Kishorikant Mishra's recollections, his attachment to the mother tongue is linked to his experience of debates at school. His association with the Mithila Cultural Council in Kolkata transforms a personal interest into an institutional campaign. Of particular importance are the practical labour of publishing a magazine and the concern for consistency in spelling. In this account, Mithila Mihir and the printing system are not merely technical matters; they become questions of linguistic standardisation.

Efforts to construct a commemorative image of Vidyapati, the campaign for a postage stamp, and appeals to record Maithili in the census demonstrate that the language movement operated simultaneously on three levels: literary prestige, the formation of public symbols, and demographic visibility. Nevertheless, the historical claims made in the interview should not be accepted as conclusively established facts. They are the memories of a participant and ought to be evaluated against independent documentation.

A Conversation with Ramlochan Thakur: The Triangle of Activism, Editing, and Theatre

Ramlochan Thakur's responses disclose the institutional network of Maithili public life. The Maithili Mukti Morcha, magazine editing, the translation of plays, poetry, the organisation of campaigns, and encouragement for emerging writers appear not as isolated pursuits but as components of a coordinated strategy for language and culture. The discussion of collective readings and literary gatherings in conditions of limited publication raises fundamental questions about literary democracy.

The interview's greatest significance lies in its recognition that literary history cannot be reduced to a printed catalogue of works. Gatherings such as Sampark, short-lived magazines, writing under pseudonyms, and collaborative editing are also understood as foundations of a creative culture. A tension nevertheless remains: how precise is personal recollection, and how specific are institutional dates and narratives? Research therefore requires comparison with contemporary periodicals and records of events.

A Conversation with Dr Virendra Mallik: Criticism, Communication, and Generational Change

The conversation with Virendra Mallik raises the question of a literary figure's intellectual self-positioning. Nabonarayan Mishra places Mallik's reflections on literary development, theatre, the creative community, and a changing environment within a wider historical context. Thus the material moves beyond an individual writer's autobiography to illuminate relationships throughout the Maithili literary world.

Across all three interviews the questioner sometimes appears more a cultural organiser than a critic. This is simultaneously a strength and a weakness: proximity yields trust and rare information, but the rigour of follow-up questioning is not invariably consistent. Researchers need to remain alert to this duality.

Essays: Kolkata's Living Cultural Archive

The essays form the historical backbone of the collection. Its fifteen pieces include reminiscences, personal portraits, accounts of institutions, histories of magazines, reflections on folktales, autobiographical recollections, and theatrical documentation. The central tendency of Mishra's prose is to transform scattered experiences into memory capable of serving a social purpose. In this context the author's "I" is not simply an emblem of self-display; it often provides an entrance into collective experience.

Ramlochan Thakur: From the Individual to a Social Tradition

Read together, "Ramlochan Thakur as I See Him" and "Hari Is Infinite, and Infinite Are His Stories" reveal two forms of literary portraiture. The first emphasises Ramlochan's public accomplishments as a writer, editor, and activist; the second, through an extended reminiscence, foregrounds the private dimensions of friendship, dialogue, organisation, and bereavement. The story of the institutions surrounding a single person gradually becomes a narrative of personal grief.

The critical question here is that formal examination of Ramlochan's literary writing is relatively limited, while admiring accounts of his campaigns occupy much more space. Yet this tendency cannot be dismissed as wholly non-literary, for the making of exemplary personalities has itself been a cultural practice within the literature of Maithili activism. What is needed is a separation of reverence from historical scrutiny.

Rajnandan Lal Das: Magazines, Institutional Leadership, and the Politics of Credit

"A Man of His Age: Shri Rajnandan Lal Das" and "Rajnandan Lal Das, an Epoch-Making Figure" connect the portrayal of an individual to the history of literary journalism. References to Akhar, Karnamrit, Karna Goshti, and Maithili cultural activities disclose the continuity of the labour involved in publication. The author's principal concern is to accord due recognition to the

organisation of magazines, editorial fearlessness, and communal support in the development of literature.

The overlapping coverage in these two essays also raises a question for the critic: how clearly are the differences in fact between a brief tribute and an extended portrait, the repetition of similar claims, and the criteria for assessments based on memory distinguished? Ignoring this question would make it harder to understand the writer's historical undertaking.

Prabodh Babu and Lakshman Jha "Sagar": A Poetics of Intellectual Affection and Remembrance

"A Resolute Advocate of Mithila and Maithili: Professor Prabodh Babu" brings public contribution and personal closeness together. The author does not merely enumerate achievements; he recalls encounters, unfulfilled wishes, death, and the poignant sense of unrealised cultural possibilities. One dimension of the value of intellectual life thus becomes emotional and ethical.

In "Sagarji, Endowed with Every Virtue," the warmth of dialogue and the episode of mediation are especially notable. In praising a distinguished figure, the author also records his own modest role. The value of this mode of writing lies in its recognition that a literary community is formed not only through agreement among thinkers but also through the everyday effort to resolve disagreements.

Mithila Vikas Parishad: Institutional Cooperation and Competition

"Mithila Vikas Parishad, Kolkata: As I Saw It" recounts both institutional solidarity and mutual distrust. The author acknowledges the achievements of a particular organisation but does not evade criticism of the distance that developed among different bodies. The essay prevents the movement's history from becoming merely a narrative of glory: founding an institution is an accomplishment, but personal ego, factionalism, and the boycott of events can diminish its benefit to the community.

A distinctive feature of this account is that the author also brings into view the position of Kokil Manch, an organisation with which he himself was associated. The piece is therefore a document of personal positionality as well as historical events, allowing room for self-criticism even while declaring its commitments.

Pitambar Pathak and Babu Saheb Chaudhary: The Human Face of the Language Movement

"A Hero of the Maithili Movement: Pitambar Pathak" remembers a person who worked continually behind institutional activities. The author discusses the recruitment of younger people, the preparation of successors, and the cultivation of collective working practices. The account of a sudden death gives the remembrance its emotional ending, carrying public history into the experience of private loss.

"On Babu Saheb Chaudhary" opens up the cultural psychology of linguistic activism. Its discussion of Maithili songs, dahakan, women's voices, theatre,

and the mother tongue's connection with domestic life does not make the preservation of a language dependent solely on official recognition. Although it is not beyond question to regard women of the folk community as the sole guardians of tradition, concern for oral culture remains a valuable aspect of this prose.

The Maithili Movement in Calcutta and Mithila Darshan: The Public Pathway of the Magazine

"The Maithili Movement in Calcutta and Mithila Darshan" portrays a living history of linguistic struggle in a migrant city. Through the magazine, writers, activists, teachers, and the diasporic community become connected. The generic range of its published material—linguistics, fiction, poetry, one-act plays, and drama—constitutes important evidence for viewing a periodical as a collective intellectual platform.

Numerous names and details of publication are assembled in this essay. Although such informational density is useful, the sequence of events is not always orderly; researchers still need to compare the lists with the contents of contemporary issues. The essay's importance for the history of literary journalism lies not merely in making claims, but in offering lines of inquiry that can be independently verified.

"Smriti Akhar": Theatre Within Autobiographical Remembrance

"Smriti Akhar" narrates a cultural journey from the attempt to stage performances in a village to the stage of a great city. How an institution was founded, how performers came together, how women's participation on stage developed, and how the labour of training and direction was apportioned—such details disclose the social foundations of theatre. The references to Ganga Jha's direction and the active contributions of Kiran Jha and other performers place collective theatrical practice at the centre of the discussion.

The work also describes the author's institutional responsibilities. The critical importance of the memoir arises from the fact that its author was not merely a spectator of theatre but participated in running the organisation. Yet precisely because of this proximity, the account of achievements requires further consideration alongside failures, audience composition, theatrical language, and experiments in staging.

"Maithili Folktales": The Preservation and Limits of Folk Literature

In "Maithili Folktales," the author identifies a gap between the breadth of oral tradition and the scarcity of published collections. Oral narratives transmit social and intergenerational memory, but their circulation may be restricted without written anthologies. The discussion of existing examples of Maithili folktale collection thus raises an institutional question about the work of preservation.

Folktales, however, are not merely objects to be safeguarded. The circumstances of storytelling, the narrator's social location, dialect differences, gendered perspectives, and changing versions of a tale also demand study. The

essay correctly identifies the need for collection while leaving ample scope for further research into the relations of power and formal variation within folktales.

"Mithila Mihir and the Editor": The Aesthetics of Print Publicity

"Mithila Mihir and the Editor" brings together the history of literary journalism, the personal influence of an editor, and the standardisation of language. The author's attention falls on the broader community of stories, novels, plays, and ideas that developed within the magazine. Beneath the lucid prose also lies the pain of historical loss: missing issues of a regular periodical, scattered contributions, and unresolved questions of editorial discipline.

Reading this essay alongside the interview with Kishorikant Mishra makes clear that uniform spelling is not simply a linguistic decision. It is a public compact produced through the labour of printing and editorial practice. The collection makes an original contribution in this direction.

"Ajay Singh, an Exceptional Well-Wisher of Maithili": Affection, Mourning, and Public Life

The essay devoted to Ajay Singh links personal acquaintance with an assessment of communal service. References to a death during the COVID period and the decline of cultural institutions evoke the passing of an entire generation. Such commemorative writing can preserve the threads of cultural connection for future researchers, although independent confirmation of events, dates, and contributions remains necessary for historical study.

"Maithili Theatre and Kolkata": From a Performance List to Theatre History

This essay represents one of the collection's fundamental documentary achievements. By bringing together details of theatre practitioners, playwrights, translations, productions, auditoriums, and direction, it seeks to move the history of Maithili drama beyond a history of written plays alone. Information about productions associated with Kokil Manch could make possible a study of the social life of theatre, its organisational capacity, and the cultural geography of a migrant city.

The dates and names contained in this list are valuable as leads for research, but the list should not be treated as a complete substitute for an independently verified chronology. What were the performances like? How did the acting of women's roles change? What social groups comprised the audience? What forms did ticketing and rehearsals take? The essay does not fully and systematically answer these questions. Nevertheless, the work of documentation deserves an appropriate place in literary history.

Separate Textual Analyses of the Stories

The collection's fiction encompasses rural life, the hardships of migration, the competing claims of family welfare and individual interest, the social constraints of marriage, the ethics of money and labour, public consciousness of language, and satire. In many stories an explicit moral judgement arrives at

the end; elsewhere the final scene gives readers the opportunity to construct meaning for themselves. Their internal differences must be preserved in interpretation, lest this entire fictional world be oversimplified by the designation "didactic."

"Such Things Happen Too": The Construction of a Comic Scene

The subject of this short story is Mohanji's first visit to a cinema. In the darkness, he fails to lower the folding seat and remains suspended on the armrests; the interval lights reveal the cause of the misunderstanding. The humour arises not primarily from verbal wit but from the delayed revelation of a visual situation and the reader's incomplete information. The meaning of the title is reversed at the close.

The contrast between a modern place of entertainment and rural experience appears here as gentle satire. Rather than humiliating the character, the storyteller transforms his ignorance into a social experience. Brevity, well-timed disclosure, and humorous dialogue account for the story's success.

"A Ripe Mango": The Moral Perspective of a Child

A five-year-old boy insists on sharing the mango allotted to him with his paternal cousin, while his father argues that their households are separate and that the cousin's family enjoys greater comforts. The child's instinctive empathy calls the adults' divisive realism into question. The mango is not merely something to eat; it becomes a symbol of justice and participation within the joint family.

The story's particular strength lies in making the child's experience, rather than the narrator's instruction, the centre of the moral disagreement. Nevertheless, the father's position is rather easily presented as selfishness; the complexities of economic necessity receive little attention. In the form of the short story, however, this compression also intensifies the effect.

"The Complications of a Journey": The Comic Predicament of Migrant Life

Pressure at work, the unexpected holiday created by a shutdown in Bengal, memories of home, travel by night, rain, insecurity, social expectations in the village, and fear of absence from the office—all coexist in this story of a journey. What begins as a brief spell of leave becomes an apparently endless succession of obligations. The family calls the protagonist home, but salaried employment continues to hold him captive.

The formal problem of this work is its expansiveness: numerous episodes, interesting in themselves, sometimes dissipate the narrative tension. Even so, the sequence of events, the anticipations created by conversations with his wife, the obstacles along the road, and the delay caused by a wedding procession yield an authentic sense of the psychological divisions of migrant life. Comedy arises here from the impossible choice between livelihood and human relationships.

"The Wheel of Time": Inheritance, Property, and Labour

The story of Upendra, a fatherless boy, encompasses the acquisitiveness of relatives seeking inherited property, a family in crisis, and his advancement through education and hard work. The boy's vulnerable social position is transformed into a narrative of self-making. The conduct of his kinsmen and the dispute over property rights provide significant clues to the social history of rural Mithila.

By the end, the protagonist's economic and social standing has become secure. Moral recompense is evident in this structure, while the multilayered examination of power within the struggle remains comparatively restricted. Yet the insistence that labour and education matter more than inherited wealth is a sensitive indication of contemporary social change.

"An Ideal Marriage": The Market in Dowry and the Resistance of Youth

The wealthy Narayan Babu seeks to "recover" the money spent on his daughter's marriage through the marriage of his son. Having reached an agreement with the bride's family, he decides to stop the wedding when the remaining payment is not received. At this decisive moment, his son Rajan opposes paternal authority, returns the money exchanged, and insists on a marriage without dowry.

The story employs a dramatic public declaration to oppose a pernicious social custom. Its strength is that resistance arises within the household itself; its limitation is that the complex social institution of dowry appears to be resolved immediately by the moral courage of one conscientious young man. Nevertheless, in the historical circumstances of the story, the public significance of such a scene in challenging the normalisation of dowry cannot be denied.

"The Fruits of Benevolence": Irony and Moral Steadfastness

People who have benefited from Hari Babu's generosity conspire against him, and a violent robbery results in the death of his son Vinay. His family advises him to stop helping others, but he refuses to abandon his commitment to benevolence. The title turns the customary expectation that good deeds yield good rewards into tragic irony.

The story's deeper question concerns the possibility of practising virtue in a society without justice. The storyteller presents Hari Babu's moral resolve as a supreme human value. Critically, there is little political or economic exploration of the relationship between violence and benevolence, while the villains are reduced to social types. Even so, the tragic conclusion raises the story above the level of easy moral instruction.

"The Industry of a Millionaire": The Reversal of Ridicule

A quarrel over a water queue in a Maithil-dominated neighbourhood of Delhi produces a mocking nickname for a married couple. The derisive term "millionaire" subsequently becomes an indication of actual achievement

through the protagonist's work. The story exploits urban scarcity, public discipline, and the humour of social naming.

Its weakness is that the wife's conduct is interpreted through gender stereotypes, while the final turn from labour to spectacular wealth is rather simplified. Nevertheless, the transformation of public mockery into a sign of economic advancement remains entertaining.

"The Dignity of Maithili": Public Reading Culture in the Village

Structured around a telephone conversation, this brief work imagines rural public spaces—the barber's shop, tea stall, and library—as centres for the dissemination of language and literature. A character explains that Maithili magazines can be present not only in the city but also in communal gatherings in villages. The point of the story is not official recognition but the making of readers.

The narrative tension is very slight; the piece becomes almost a scene expressing a commitment to language. Yet this brief exchange contains a democratic dream of modern Maithili public life: literature should not remain the exclusive possession of an educated elite.

"A Happy Coincidence": Wedding Arrangements, Cooperation, and Chance

In this extended narrative, the arrangements for a family wedding, the difficulty of obtaining leave from employment, experiences of the village, demands of kinship, financial management, and the uncertainties of a wedding procession intertwine. Unexpected circumstances eventually open the possibility of a new relationship. The story offers a detailed portrait of the invisible organisational labour of family life.

The living detail of small practical decisions is invaluable: who must be informed, who must be approached, who will take charge of a task, and how the expectations of the other family will be met. When these matters become too expansive, the narrative centre can lose its firmness. In this work the boundary between fiction and personal reminiscence appears to become deliberately indistinct.

"The Duty of the Age": The Fire of the Village Hearth and the Coldness of Relationships

Bitter winter weather, the communal fire in a village, collective conversation, and Lalbihari's neglect by his family form an especially successful narrative arrangement. There is warmth in the fire outside, but the coldness of ingratitude within the family. An elder brother who has sacrificed for the education and establishment of his younger brothers receives neglect in return.

The shared scene in the spacious village veranda gives the story's moral conflict a locally embodied sensibility. The final silence leaves room for several interpretations; this openness is an example of the writer's relatively mature narrative craft. Here, the language of social responsibility emerges through scene and silence more than through authorial commentary.

"The Fruits of Arrogance": Local Power and Social Retaliation

Bachchi Babu's economic dominance and insulting behaviour bring about his social isolation. A minor dispute becomes a legal battle, and, when he fails to obtain society's support, his power weakens. The title itself anticipates the moral direction of the ending.

The work approaches a concise parable: the punishment of pride. It gives little scrutiny to how justifiable the community's collective retaliation may itself be. Yet this short story effectively distinguishes the power of wealth from social esteem.

A Separate Consideration of the Verse: Song, Mourning, and Resistance

The collection's verse is varied. There are public pronouncements in free rhythm, songs with recurring refrains, memorial lyrics, invocations of the Goddess, and the humour and playfulness of Holi. By contemporary critical standards, it would be mistaken to categorise all these works either as "great poetry" or as "mere propaganda songs." Their achievements emerge through separate examinations of subject, rhythm, linguistic energy, and communal purpose.

"On the New Year" and "A Traveller on an Endless Journey": The Public Expression of Bereavement

Identified as the author's first published work, "On the New Year" remembers the deceased Lalit Babu against the background of collective New Year celebrations. The collision between a fresh beginning in time and the absence of an individual generates the poem's central emotional tension. "A Traveller on an Endless Journey" brings together memories of the creative work of Yatri-Nagarjun and questions of his social recognition.

In both poems death signifies not merely private grief but a sense of cultural diminishment. Yet at certain points direct expressions of praise limit the development of poetic metaphor. Despite this restriction, the historical sensibility remains important.

"The Burden of the Earth," "What an Achievement," and "Irony": Critical Voices from Within the Community

"The Burden of the Earth" registers anger against the short lives of literary institutions, selfishness, and ingratitude. "What an Achievement" reveals the strange coexistence of public success and a hunger for credit. "Irony" sharpens the critical impulse in a socio-political setting. In all three poems the speaker is not an observer outside the community but a participant wounded from within it.

The poetic language of these works is declarative. Direct address and an interrogative rhythm make them suitable for public recitation, but a density of distinctive imagery is not found everywhere. The historical value of the

writer's anger and the aesthetic limitations of its expression must both be acknowledged.

"A New Song": The Refrain Against Corruption

In "A New Song," a recurring refrain becomes a voice for public utterance; the corruption of political leaders and officials, inflation, unequal distribution, and the helplessness of ordinary people provide its themes. The editorial note also raises the question of the work's generic classification as a song. This context demonstrates an important principle: a metrical designation or genre label does not in itself establish poetic form. One must examine the internal rhythm, refrain, repetitions, and capacity for performance.

"Phagua," "An Aarti for the Queen of Brides," and "Gifts of Love at Holi": The Plurality of Celebration

"Phagua" evokes the season, colour, food, music, and communal togetherness. In "An Aarti for the Queen of Brides," the gestures of devotional worship are transformed into domestic affection and festive humour; its chief artistic device is the playful adaptation of religious language. "Gifts of Love at Holi" consists of a sequence of brief addresses written to particular individuals, making the festival an occasion for recording social relationships.

The value of these works lies not only in elevated poetic criteria but also in their living use within Maithili public culture. The list of names in "Gifts of Love at Holi," in particular, may be read as a small archive of Kolkata's social networks.

"A Literary Lamp," "Tribute," and "Song of Mourning": Poetry as the Preservation of Memory

In these poems a tribute is not simply an outpouring of emotion; it is also a record of a departed literary worker's labours and an acknowledgement of the community's debt. In "A Literary Lamp," the conventional symbol of the lamp expresses the continuity of literary dedication. In "Tribute," the arrangement according to the letters of a name becomes a formal technique for mourning. "Song of Mourning" joins recollections of cultural symbols and events to the campaign for recognition of Maithili.

The combination of memoiristic information and emotional intensity is valuable, but the autonomy of poetry is sometimes burdened by the weight of factual reference. For readers today, these poems are simultaneously literature and documents of remembrance.

Two Forms of "Invocation to Bhagavati": Folk Devotion and Self-Examination

The invocations to Bhagavati collected in two different places are characterised by surrender, confession of sin, expressions of suffering, and faith in the Mother Goddess. Here the language of traditional devotional poetry makes room for modern social anxieties and personal distress. Repeated forms of address create a rhythm oriented towards an audience.

The literary importance of these two poems lies not in a new philosophical doctrine but in the local adaptation of emotion. Between private vulnerability and the Goddess's public image, the poems form a bridge to the religious sensibility of the community.

"Some People," "This Is Not a Proper View," and "Maithili Speaks to Her Children": Poems of Dissent

"Some People" raises questions of world peace and violence; "This Is Not a Proper View" directly addresses differences of literary and ideological opinion; in "Maithili Speaks to Her Children," the mother tongue acquires a voice of her own and questions her children. The personification of language in the last work opens up a particularly effective possibility of poetic form.

All three works display a firm desire to awaken the community's critical conscience. Nevertheless, rather than treating a statement about contemporary politics as poetry merely because it is expressed in verse, one must assess its poetic complexity, irony, and internal voices. The author's commitment is beyond doubt, but commitment cannot itself substitute for craft.

"Accept This Loving Embrace" and "The Maithili Festival": Different Moments in the Public Sphere

"Accept This Loving Embrace" combines the beauty of spring, domestic romance, and the occasion of Holi. An editorial indication that the poem has appeared under a different title raises an interesting issue of textual transmission: the same work may have circulated under different names. "The Maithili Festival" gives song form to the community's delight at Maithili securing a place in the Constitution.

The first poem employs the folk idiom of private attraction; the second is a celebratory song honouring a public accomplishment. In both, simple language structured around a refrain lends itself to communal recitation. The comparison reveals the place of Mishra's poetry in both private and collective celebrations.

An Integrated Assessment Through Poetics and Narratology

In Nabonarayan Mishra's stories, the plot often leads towards the moral consequences of individual conduct. The child's emotional question in "A Ripe Mango," the public resistance in "An Ideal Marriage," and the punishment enacted in "The Fruits of Arrogance" represent three different models of moral resolution. Compared with these, "The Duty of the Age" is a more substantial poetic achievement: the conjunction of nature description, spatial composition, and a character's silence produces meaning more multiple than a plainly articulated lesson.

From the perspective of rasa, humour, pathos, indignation, and devotion are all present. The humour of "Such Things Happen Too" rests on an unexpected revelation; the pathos of "The Fruits of Benevolence" on moral

steadfastness; the comedy of "An Aarti for the Queen of Brides" on the adaptation of a familiar ritual form; and the pathos of "The Duty of the Age" on contrasting images of heat and cold. In terms of dhvani, or suggestion, the effect is greatest when the author allows the scene to do its work instead of stating the conclusion.

In the stories, the natural ease of Maithili dialogue, social forms of address, and descriptions of domestic conduct create authenticity. Yet the author's explanatory sentences often restrict the characters' independence. With fewer concluding moral remarks, the irony already present in these narratives might have become more intense. In the poems, the rhythm of song is often comparatively spontaneous, whereas the weight of assertion is more visible in free verse.

An assessment of female characters reveals a tension. On one side, the child's rejection of a father's divisive attitudes, a young man's resistance to dowry, and references to women's active participation in theatre open progressive possibilities. On the other, some stories confine the wife to the stereotype of a quarrelsome woman or a source of domestic pressure. This contradiction illuminates the coexistence of tradition and reformist morality in Mishra's creative practice.

Comparative Discussion in Relation to the History of Maithili Literature

One influential current in the writing of Maithili literary history proceeds through Vidyapati, Jyotirishwar, the development of modern prose, Yatri-Nagarjun, Harimohan Jha, Rajkamal Chaudhary, and newer literary movements. Its central concern is the language and craft of literary works and the intellectual innovations of their authors. Nabonarayan Mishra does not simply add another writer to this tradition; he changes the questions posed by history. What part do institutions, performances, editors, book distribution, and reading communities play in keeping literature alive?

In a comparison of narrative technique, Harimohan Jha's social humour displays a more sustained psychological satire, while Nabonarayan's "Such Things Happen Too" offers brief comedy built on a visual mistake. The democratic poetry of Yatri-Nagarjun displays a marked multiplicity of meaning in both language and satire, whereas Nabonarayan's political verse often remains close to immediate public declaration. This comparison is not a claim about influence or imitation, but a critical means of understanding differences of form.

In the theatrical tradition associated with Mahendra Malangia, playwriting represents an autonomous creative practice. In the case of Kokil Manch, Nabonarayan's significance extends beyond the written play to performance, organisation, and the cultivation of an audience. To regard this as a lesser contribution would be a one-sided view of literary history. "What was performed on the stage?" and "How was the stage made possible?" are equally necessary questions.

Kolkata emerges as a distinctive centre in the diasporic geography of Maithili literature. Connections among employment, printing, higher education, institutions, book distribution, movements, and theatre give Maithili literature its public shape in the city. Nabonarayan's prose presents Kolkata not simply as a site of the pain of migration but as a centre of cultural labour and creative possibility. In doing so, the collection challenges the artificial division between "Maithili literature" and "the Maithili movement."

The Videha project of parallel literary history accords importance to the study of neglected writers, little magazines, folk literature, theatre, and linguistic diversity. The collection enters into a natural dialogue with this critical framework, but the two should not be treated as identical. Every claim requires renewed scrutiny according to the criteria of historical evidence, textual form, and social representation.

Literary Journalism, Institutions, and the Evidentiary Structure of Historiography

In the collection, Mithila Mihir, Mithila Darshan, Akhar, Karnamrit, and other magazines appear not merely as titles but as institutions of communal memory. Continuity in the publication of journals, editorial labour, the content of individual issues, and the cultivation of readers together become constituent elements of a language movement. A literary history concerned only with celebrated books in print deprives periodicals of their contribution.

Historical investigation, however, should not give every kind of evidence the same standing. The writer's direct participation, an interviewee's recollection, an editor's introduction, a record of an event, and a later reminiscence each have different conditions of reliability. In using the collection, chronology, alternative memories, and the actual existence of specific publications need to be independently checked. Such caution does not diminish the collection's importance; it more clearly differentiates the categories of evidence.

Questions of social inclusion are also essential to a critical reading of institutional history. Which performers' names recur? How visible are women actors, technical assistants, volunteer organisers, Dalit and backward communities, and ordinary members of the audience? The silences of a record that names particular people are themselves subjects for history. From this perspective the collection inspires further social and cultural scholarship.

Editorial Achievement and Textual Caution

The most significant achievement of Ashish Anchinhar's editorial labour is the preservation of dispersed material. Bringing together personal essays, memorial volumes, periodicals, interviews, earlier publications, and difficult-to-obtain writings constitutes a major convenience for readers and researchers. In the editor's introduction, he also acknowledges that

information about the first publication of the material is not uniformly available and that additional writings may come to light.

A subsequent critical edition should assemble, in a consistent form, the year of first publication of each work, the relevant magazine issue, variants of original titles, dates of composition, and information about republication. Comparative documentation of the relationship between apparently similar poems published under different titles, the sequence of works, multiple accounts of the same event, and conflicting evidence about institutional dates would prove particularly useful.

Rather than relying on verbatim quotation, this review adopts a contextual analysis of characters, sequences of events, interview topics, and ideas. Since the textual forms of the available works have not always remained uniformly stable, direct quotations have been avoided where the precise original wording could not be established beyond doubt. The aim of this restraint is to protect historical reliability.

Overall Evaluation: Achievements, Limitations, and Future Possibilities

Nabonarayan Mishra's literary achievement operates on three principal levels. First, he gives words to the history of labour and events within Maithili cultural institutions. Second, he creates effective situations of moral contradiction in short fiction and social episodes. Third, through poems and songs, he voices feelings about language and community. Among these, the essays and interviews hold a particularly distinctive place, since the author's direct participation reveals the neglected history of the world he describes.

In the fiction, the compact moral question of “A Ripe Mango,” the laughter of “Such Things Happen Too,” the resistance of “An Ideal Marriage,” the tragic persistence of “The Fruits of Benevolence,” and the silence of “The Duty of the Age” deserve special notice. “The Complications of a Journey” and “A Happy Coincidence” are engaging in their wealth of lived experience, but their narrative structure is less taut. The intensely public nature of the poetry makes it effective as historical testimony, though its poetic complexity is uneven.

The collection's intellectual limitations are principally visible in the tendency towards simple moral resolutions, excessive reverence, and certain conventional stereotypes of social relations. The author's attachment to his mother tongue is powerful; yet a wider space for literary disagreement, alternative viewpoints, and marginal experiences would have made the portrait more comprehensive. The purpose of this criticism is not to devalue the contribution but to determine its proper contours.

Ultimately, Nabonarayan Mishra Samagra is more than a measure of a single writer's independent literary achievement: it is part of the collective autobiography of the Maithili-speaking public sphere. Its true value will emerge when Maithili literary history is written through the relationships

among the city's stages, institutional meetings, magazine editors, unacknowledged workers, village readers, folktales, and language movements. The book is not merely a static monument to the past; it also presents a set of research questions for the future.

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REVIEW 2

THE INDEPENDENT SPIRIT: ARVIND THAKUR

A Polyphonic Reading of the Writer and His Work

Book under review: Swatantracheta: Arvind Thakur—Vyaktitva-Krititva (The Independent Spirit: Arvind Thakur—Life and Work) · Edited by Ashish Anchinhar · Shashi Prakashan, Supaul · First edition: 2020 · ISBN 978-81-948818-0-3

Abstract

Swatantracheta, edited by Ashish Anchinhar, is not an ordinary volume of praise devoted to a literary personality. It is a critical document assembling numerous voices concerning Arvind Thakur's writings, social presence, intellectual dissent, and reception among his contemporaries. Developed from a special issue of Videha devoted to Arvind Thakur, it brings critical essays on fiction, poetry, and ghazals into dialogue with an interview, reminiscences, autobiographical reflections, and a brief biography. Literary value and the very process through which a literary personality is constructed are consequently brought under scrutiny. This study analyses the collection's editorial design; separately examines the political and social narrative technique of the story collection Anharak Virodh Me (Against the Darkness),

the people's perspective in the poems of Parti Tuti Rahal Achhi (The Fallow Land Is Breaking), and the debate over the formal identity of the ghazals in Bahurupiya Pradesh Me (In a Province of Disguises). Its principal purpose is to examine the interrelations of village life, ideological resistance, stylistic experiment, and a parallel culture of publication within literary history. The overall conclusion is that the collection's chief significance lies not in producing an unquestionable monument to one writer, but in preserving the agreements, disagreements, and critical incompleteness within its own pages.

Keywords: Arvind Thakur; Swatantracheta; Ashish Anchinhar; Videha; criticism of fiction; rural consciousness; Maithili ghazal; communalism; resistance; literary history.

The Nature of the Book and the Basis of This Review

It would be a fundamental error to read Swatantracheta as a new original collection of Arvind Thakur's poems, stories, or ghazals. Rather, it is an edited volume comprising the evaluations of numerous critics of his creative life, the writer's own statements, and the memories of those who knew him closely. A critic approaching this volume must remain attentive to two levels of enquiry: the value of the author's creative work and the value of the critical assumptions formed around that work. At the first level, one asks what social conflicts the fiction presents, what kinds of folk language the poetry employs, and what formal discipline governs the ghazals. At the second, one asks what theoretical presuppositions the critics bring to their readings and where personal proximity to the writer strengthens or weakens criticism.

The volume's editorial history is decisive for literary historiography. It evolved in 2020 from a Videha special issue devoted to Arvind Thakur, originally published in 2015. The editorial introduction explicitly states that some original works were removed and replaced with later criticism and memoirs. Thus the magazine special issue and the subsequent book do not contain precisely the same texts. To call the latter merely a reprint would obscure the editor's active role in selection. This distinction matters in literary documentation, for the changing contents of the collection reveal how the writer's reception, rereading, and evaluation evolved over time.

The present study reads the collection's contents in relation to the original critical essays published in Videha. Where a collected essay makes a claim about an original creative work, that claim is not treated as a substitute for evidence established through direct reading of the work itself. Such caution is necessary: the argument for a writer's significance must be sustained not by an imposing critical sentence alone, but by the described plot structure, characterisation, linguistic texture, and disagreements among critics.

Editorial Architecture: A Polyphonic Critical Archive Rather Than a Biography

The editor arranges the volume in the order of criticism, interview, reminiscences, autobiographical statement, and concise biography. Within

the critical material, essays on fiction, the social functions of poetry, debates about ghazals, and reflections on the relationship between personality and work stand together. These are followed by an interview conducted by Munnaji; reminiscences by Binay Bhushan, Shailendra Anand, Ajit Azad, and others; and finally the writer's autobiographical statement and life sketch. The sequence creates a reading journey from external evaluation towards the writer's inward self-examination.

This design turns a creative writer into material for historical study, but it carries certain risks. Memoirs are shaped by closeness, affection, and selective remembrance; criticism should be governed primarily by standards of evaluation. To read both in the same emotional register may weaken analytical rigour. Yet memoirs also bring to light dimensions of society, editing, magazine publication, agrarian culture, and literary networks in the Kosi region that cannot be recovered from the dry chronology of literary history. The book's strength lies in preserving these generic differences within a single volume.

The editorial introduction also acknowledges that the writer's role as a critic and thinker has not been adequately represented. Rather than concealing the volume's limitations, this admission establishes questions for future research. When numerous commentaries on a writer's fiction and ghazals survive but his independent critical thought is comparatively underrepresented, any portrayal of his intellectual world will inevitably remain incomplete. In this instance, the book's self-acknowledged limits become a foundation for new historical enquiry.

The Grammar of Resistance: Darkness Is a System, Not an Event

In a critical reading of Arvind Thakur's fictional world, “darkness” cannot be understood simply as an emblem of ordinary despair or the natural night. It encompasses power, social prejudice, divisions of caste and religious community, inequalities of justice, and individual inaction. Thus the title of Anharak Virodh Me (Against the Darkness) is not merely a metaphorical gesture; it is an intellectual thread joining diverse social conditions. Dr Yoganand Jha, Gajendra Thakur, and Ashish Chaman identify this thread in different ways, but their essays do not arrive at a single judgement.

One aspect of darkness concerns the moral degradation of public life; another concerns the doubt, fear, and helplessness that such degradation awakens in the individual. Resistance here does not mean only declarative indignation. A crucial distinction separates the circumstances a character can understand from the capacity that character possesses to escape them. Literary achievement arises when the writer does more than identify one side as virtuous and the other as wicked—when the work also reveals how the social order generates such divisions.

At times, the critics represented in the collection accord greater importance to a story's ideological commitment than to the possibility of complex characterisation or artistic uncertainty. This essay argues that resistance-

centred fiction becomes socially meaningful when its causal relationships and artistic evidence remain credible. To predetermine a moral answer risks reducing fiction to an illustration of an idea.

A Separate Reading of "Khissa Siyar Yar": Political Satire

The very title Khissa Siyar Yar suggests that the human character of political power will be examined through animal imagery. Dr Yoganand Jha identifies various embodiments of party-based self-interest, the desire for electoral nominations, flattery, and political opportunism. Ashish Chaman connects its political moment with the earlier "lantern era"; Gajendra Thakur's analysis foregrounds the discrepancy between public morality and partisan behaviour. In the three-way dialogue among these readings, the story becomes more than a satire on one political party: it portrays a wider crisis in political culture.

The principal mechanism of satire is the gap between what the characters say and what they do. Leaders who speak in the language of principles behave differently when personal office, their children's employment, recommendations, or calculations of political support are at stake. By converting such duplicity into accessible irony, the story discloses the unreliability of public language. Yet the number of characters and the transparency of the allegory sometimes risk turning the fiction into a gallery of social types. If every character remains only a representative of a political vice, independent psychological life may disappear.

Comparison with Harimohan Jha's humour in the Maithili satirical tradition may be useful, but it would be wrong to regard the two as identical kinds of comedy. Harimohan Jha's satire is notably concerned with social conventions, learned mockery, and domestic contradictions of personality. The political humour discernible in the criticism of this story is more direct, hostile to opportunism, and focused on public authority. Laughter becomes a means of recognising the betrayal of society's reformist ideals.

A Separate Reading of "Piyasal Pani": The Moral Double Standard Imposed on Women

Piyasal Pani (Thirsting Water) appears to be one of the collection's most consequential stories. The social judgement of Narayanpurwali's life is shaped by patriarchal authority, a double standard in sexual restraint, economic dependence, and rumour. Dr Yoganand Jha foregrounds the woman's psychological pain and the workings of collective persecution; Ashish Chaman raises a pointed question about the hypocrisy of the society that observes and judges her. Male incapacity is concealed while a woman's conduct becomes a matter of public accusation. This is the ethical centre of the narrative arrangement.

Analytically, the story does more than seek to arouse pity. Its structure of knowledge is crucial: what readers and characters initially believe about Narayanpurwali is overturned by information revealed later. This reversal

makes the very process of judgement in a misogynistic society suspect. By delaying the disclosure of truth, the narrative challenges the reader's already-formed conclusions. In this sense, the story's form becomes part of the social criticism it seeks to articulate.

But the inquiry does not end there. If the woman's innocence is ultimately established through proof of the man's biological incapacity, to what extent does the story affirm her independent desire or autonomous existence on their own terms? Its rebuttal of social accusations is powerful, yet the full scope of the woman's voice and capacity for decision remains open to critical examination. Such a double evaluation makes the story more meaningful than a simplified triumphal narrative of women's emancipation.

A Separate Reading of the Title Story: The Difficult Politics of Communal Harmony

The title story, "Against the Darkness," sets the everyday social relations between Hindus and Muslims against political incitement. In Dr Yoganand Jha's account, Ranjan's entrance into a Muslim neighbourhood, anger at Alimuddin's crime, and the intentions of those seeking communal division produce conflicting meanings from a single event. Social relationships appear here as a lived formation preceding religious categorisation, while violence becomes a political attempt to fracture that formation.

The central narrative tension lies in the distinction between individual responsibility for a crime and the collective stigma imposed upon an entire community. Protecting the criminal and blaming the whole community are both forms of injustice. Artistically, this situation succeeds when the characters' fear, anger, affection, and moral decisions become simultaneously intelligible. The critical essays regard this tension as a foundation for social coexistence.

Still, a reading opposed to communalism cannot rest on a poignant ending or an elevated declaration alone. It must also ask how local power, the marketplace, rumour, and public opinion create the conditions for violence. The political strength of a story centred on fraternity resides in its inclusion of this complex reality; otherwise, the message of harmony may outweigh the narrative's insight.

A Separate Reading of "Dhancha-1992" and "Prajatantra Parikatha": Opposed Strategies of Narrative

Dhancha-1992 (Structure—1992) invokes a historically devastating moment in Indian public life. Ashish Chaman attaches particular importance to the story's epistolary form, while Dr Yoganand Jha emphasises the event's social and psychological consequences and the damage done to communal trust. The use of the letter as a narrative medium allows a major political event to be viewed through individual anxiety, guilt, and private perspective. The letter-writer's limited knowledge itself becomes an instrument of meaning.

Prajatantra Parikatha (A Democratic Fable) centres on a cycle involving public protest, the murder of a doctor, an administrative response, and the moral hijacking of the movement. The reviewers' accounts distinguish the original crime, the crowd that gathers to protest against it, and the group that exploits the opportunity from within that crowd. The story exposes the ethical ambiguity of collective action: not every procession is just, and not every act of administrative repression can be justified as a defence of public welfare.

Read together, the two stories raise an essential question about democracy: when is the collective voice of the people an act of just resistance, and when does it become an instrument of political self-interest? In the first, memories of communal violence enter personal utterance; in the second, a private crime becomes the occasion for public action. This reversed relationship deepens the fictional world's intellectual force. Read separately, the stories might otherwise seem like unrelated political commentaries.

A Separate Reading of "Mus" and "Ayyasi": Labour, Shame, and Self-Deception

Ashish Chaman's interpretation of the stories Mus (Mouse) and Ayyasi (Indulgence) is interesting because he treats them not as distinct moral exempla but as potentially complementary narratives. In one, middle-class desires for consumption collide with the household's necessities; in the other, debt, ancestral property, the inability to find work, and questions of production emerge. Together they reveal a conflict between the immediate consumption of pleasure and the longer-term significance of labour.

The symbolism of Mus is particularly important. The critical essays read the mouse as an image of industrious life and the snake as a force that takes possession of the fruits of labour. Yet the metaphor is not confined to one meaning: the mouse's tenacity also brings the individual to an awareness of his own inertia. Political and personal ethical meanings are thus present together. A character who recognises an exploitative structure cannot thereby be absolved of responsibility for his own conduct.

The strength of this pair of stories lies less in their final exemplary lessons than in the psychological interval during which a character, having continually blamed his circumstances for failure, becomes a critic of his own decisions. Nevertheless, to proclaim labour a sufficient moral solution risks obscuring social capital, unequal access to resources, and the structural obstacles of unemployment. Attentive examination of these matters helps preserve the necessary distance between didactic fiction and social realism.

A Separate Reading of Caste Opportunism, the Chameleon, and the Poison of Justice

In Baikba-Phorba and Ath Girgit Gatha, the instability of political identity and the manoeuvres of organised self-interest occupy the foreground. In the former, a dispute over a personal loan becomes a collective conflict organised

along caste lines; in the latter, mutual hostility turns into alliance at the moment of electoral calculation. Both situations suggest that ideological declarations made in the name of organisation are internally driven by calculations of private advantage. The chameleon becomes a visible emblem of the political body that changes its colours.

A distinctive feature of these stories is that references to caste, though necessary for recognising social injustice, are not invariably deployed in good faith. In the episodes under discussion, the language of caste humiliation becomes a weapon for transforming a conflict over economic interests into a quarrel between two groups. Criticism must nevertheless avoid dismissing the real history of caste oppression as nothing more than a manoeuvre of opportunistic politicians. Fiction gains in balance when it distinguishes actual inequality from its political exploitation.

In Vish-Pan (Drinking Poison), the protracted legal process, the power of money, the instability of testimony, and the condition of a defeated litigant become significant. In Dr Yoganand Jha's account, the relationship between Gopalji and Chaturanan acquires a different balance of power upon entering the courts. The fictional world consequently calls into question not only individual morality but also the workings of institutions. The agent of social injustice may sometimes be a villainous character and sometimes the legal process itself. The story's realism expands with this shift.

The Ground of Poetry: Parti Tuti Rahal Achhi and the Resistant Memory of the Soil

The title Parti Tuti Rahal Achhi (The Fallow Land Is Breaking) is itself an agricultural symbol of social transformation. Fallow land denotes a condition of stasis, infertility, or the absence of prospects; breaking it suggests new labour, seed, and confidence in the future. Munnaji's essay links this agrarian metaphor with the development of the poetry and the writer's rural sensibility. Arvind Srivastava emphasises the poems' courage in opposing power and their movement beyond a feudal environment towards solidarity with ordinary people.

Poetic achievement cannot be measured by the vehemence of expressed opposition alone. When objects of everyday life, idioms of local speech, and agrarian experience move beyond immediate utility to become symbols within a poem, poetry is transformed from social documentation into art. Fallow land, cultivators, seed, labour, and the seasonal cycle establish active relationships of meaning. The poem's metaphor turns neglected soil towards new hope; yet the ethical credibility of that hope depends on its not concealing the farmer's actual insecurity and inequality.

Several critics discuss the relationship between the writer's inherited family commitment to socialism and his own social experience. Yet the quality of literary creation does not automatically follow from a family's ideology. For literary history, ancestry is context rather than evidence of artistic worth. A poem becomes valuable through its words, imagery, rhythm, and

contradictions. Responsible criticism must examine artistic accomplishment alongside the writer's declared solidarity with the people.

Rural Vocabulary, the Kosi Region, and an Alternative Modernity

The observations of Munnaji, Arvind Mishra Neeraj, and other critics establish the significance of rural vocabulary in Arvind Thakur's language. To confer literary standing on spoken village words is not merely to apply local colour or ornament folk life. It raises the decisive question of who may speak in a narrative, how much recognition a person's experience receives in society, and which forms of language may enter the literary public sphere. The natural use of village expressions can challenge elite norms of literary value.

It would also be a mistake to equate rural life with the past. Agriculture, rivers, movement, markets, political competition, printing, and urban contact in the Kosi region belong to contemporary history. The crisis of modernity has necessarily reached the author's rural setting. In this sense, the division between village and city in Thakur's fiction is not immovable; it appears as an ongoing social and cultural exchange.

A comparison with the rural language-world of Jagdish Prasad Mandal is appropriate, but its limits must be specified. Both writers give regional speech a place in literary discussion; this broad similarity does not justify treating their aesthetic perspectives as identical. The criticism of Arvind's work presents a picture in which the vitality of rural language is bound to political dissent. Further comparison would require independent, detailed examination of sound, word order, and character speech in the original writings.

The Maithili Ghazal: The Conflict Between Thematic Freedom and Formal Discipline

The debate about Bahurupiya Pradesh Me is among the most valuable sources of disagreement in the entire volume. Jagdish Chandra Thakur “Anil” accepts the concept of the “free ghazal” in defence of the writer's unrestricted mode of expression. According to his account, the collection contains sixty-six ghazals; some depart from the traditional balance of radif and qafiya, yet their social concerns and use of the pen-name, or takhallus, remain significant. Omprakash Jha, on the other hand, asks why, once the designation “ghazal” has been adopted, an artistically justified departure from the obligatory principles of bahr and qafiya should not be clearly explained.

The disagreement cannot be settled by simply taking sides. A genre is identified through the formal disciplines of its history, but new experience continually shifts the limits of its expression. If the settled pattern of qafiya or the discipline of bahr is entirely discarded, should the work still be called a ghazal or instead a new form of couplet-based poetry? The answer does not follow merely from the author's declaration of freedom. Conversely, if poetic value is measured solely by established standards, the historical potential of new social language and expressive methods may be suppressed.

Anil's essay foregrounds the collection's creative urgency and social conscience; Omprakash Jha's centres on the internal principles by which a poetic genre is constituted. Each is a necessary corrective to the other. Acceptance of the first perspective alone risks relabelling formal negligence as creative freedom; acceptance of the second alone risks severing poetry from the social energies of language and meaning. Preserving this debate within the volume is an important editorial contribution.

Bahurupiya Pradesh Me: Metaphor, Market, and Civic Irony

The title Bahurupiya Pradesh Me (In a Province of Disguises) invites us to conceive of the modern political and social world as a region constantly changing its appearance and concealing its true face. Arvind Mishra Neeraj, Ram Chaitanya Dheeraj, and Jagdish Chandra Thakur "Anil" identify concerns with farmers, markets, parliamentary culture, and social inequality in the collection. Such choices of subject prevent the Maithili ghazal from remaining confined to romance, separation, or private soliloquy.

The ghazal couplet affords particular scope for formal compression and sharp reversals of meaning. Its small scale can be especially effective in political satire, since the reader suddenly encounters the contrary meaning of a familiar declaration. Yet not every satirical couplet is thereby a ghazal. Ideological sharpness, rhythmic discipline, and the semantic autonomy of the couplet must be assessed separately. The collection therefore demands equal attention to social purpose and metrical form.

In his criticism, Ram Chaitanya Dheeraj raises questions of philosophical unity and resistance to a consumerist market. His interpretation relocates the poet's political concerns within a spiritual and social debate. This is thought-provoking, but the poet's direct experience of class is not identical to the critic's aspiration towards philosophical unity. Here, the coexistence of distinct ideological readings enlarges the collection's intellectual range.

Position in Literary History: The Parallel Development of Maithili Fiction and the Ghazal

Discussions of modern Maithili literature often proceed through the narrative renaissance, social humour, representations of rural life, new poetry, and the development of newer genres. This collection devoted to Arvind Thakur's writings gives a distinct place in that history to the contribution of a writer from the Kosi region and to political subjects in short fiction. Beyond the general question of the influence of Hindi or other languages, the book makes it possible to investigate the representation of Maithili's own social and political vocabulary.

In discussing the epistolary structure of Dhancha-1992, Ashish Chaman refers to the letter-writing of Harimohan Jha and Rajkamal Chaudhary. The historical use of this comparison lies in its recognition that the letter form in modern Maithili is not a fixed comic genre: it can also bear tragic, social, and

political sensibilities. Though the form remains similar, its emotional purpose may change. Before claiming originality for such a development, the actual textual variants and chronology of the original works must be independently examined.

The title Prajatantra Parikatha and its public subject matter may recall Phanishwarnath Renu's Parti Parikatha (Tale of the Fallow Land). Nevertheless, similarity of title cannot be treated as evidence of influence. Renu's novelistic "fallow land" encompasses an extensive social geography and collective movement, while the criticism of Arvind's story in this volume focuses on a shorter political allegory and immediate public reactions. This difference does not diminish literary history; rather, it clarifies the distinctions of scale and emotional force in narrative form.

Anil's essay refers to the grammatical projects concerned with the ghazal undertaken by Gajendra Thakur and Ashish Anchinhar. Against that background, the debate about formal freedom in Bahurupiya Pradesh Me becomes even sharper. A new genre enters literary history not solely through an author's desire but through collective disputes involving readers, editors, grammarians, and critics. Swatantracheta is therefore a document of generic history as well as the history of literary creation.

Arvind Thakur as a Thinker: Cultural Questions Beyond Poetry

Since most of the volume's critical material concerns fiction, poetry, and ghazals, it does not adequately cover his intellectual writings, a deficiency indicated by the editorial introduction. Yet essays available in the original Videha special issue, such as "The Future of the Cultural Movement in Mithila" and "Lakshminath Gosain: Tradition, Language, and the Nirgun Sensibility," demonstrate the author's interest in social movements, linguistic power, cultural structures, and the interpretation of tradition.

In "The Future of the Cultural Movement in Mithila," the writer examines society's professed disposition towards activism in the light of institutional self-interest and histories of support for power. The argument is forceful and controversial; it would be inappropriate to derive a definitive judgement about the entire past of Maithil society from it. It nevertheless establishes that the writer's politics does not consist merely of observations about political parties: it also takes the form of cultural self-criticism. The public hypocrisy condemned in his poetry and fiction becomes the object of intellectual analysis in this essay.

The essay on Lakshminath Gosain attempts to bring together the devotional tradition, the categories of nirgun and sagun, and regional cultural influence. When tracing an extensive social history, however, broad generalisations and insufficient discussion of sources can sometimes be discerned. Criticism of such writing should distinguish the author's cultural perspective from the evidentiary standing of his historical claims. Independent editing and a source-based rereading of the writer's critical prose are necessary future tasks for understanding the full extent of his work.

Interviews, Memoirs, and Autobiographical Statements: Many Memories, Not One Biography

The significance of an interview is not limited to the factual content of its questions and answers. The words in which an author narrates his life become part of a publicly constructed self-image. Placing the interview conducted by Munnaji between critical essays and reminiscences is an editorial decision that brings the writer's own account into contact with the accounts of his critics. But spoken recollections should not be treated as wholly impartial facts about past events: memory, selection, and self-defence can play their part.

The reminiscences offer varied portraits of family, literary companionship, magazines, social presence, and personal conduct. For the literary historian this material may supplement deficient institutional archives. Yet when a memoirist makes claims about the writer's greatness, personal affection must be distinguished from artistic evaluation. Different individuals recall different aspects of the author on the basis of their own experiences, and no single reminiscence is equivalent to a complete biography.

The very title of the autobiographical statement raises a question about self-identity. Read alongside the concerns with freedom, human dignity, and social contradictions present in the stories and poems, this self-interrogation reveals a dialogue between the writer's individual existence and his creative commitments. The literary importance of the statement lies more in the openness of the question than in any settled answer of self-vindication. Its presence in the volume enables readers to consider the writer independently of the praise or disagreements voiced by critics.

Between Criticism and Panegyric: The Collection's Internal Critical Tension

Some essays in the collection are written in the register of affectionate tribute, while others use the language of explicit judgement and objection. Such a duality is common in a special issue published to honour a living author, but it calls for analysis from a scholarly perspective. Critics who praise a story's moral purpose do not invariably assess its formal limitations with equal severity. By contrast, the debate over the ghazal brings questions of generic rules to the foreground, interrupting the easy flow of commendation.

Errors, narrative sequence, character behaviour, the adequacy of metaphor, and metrical principles are genuine questions for criticism. Ashish Chaman objects to aspects of plot sequence and character decision-making; Omprakash Jha challenges defects in ghazal form; and Anil defends freer experiments in language. The presence of all these positions in a single volume testifies to its plurality. A research article drawing only on passages of praise would damage the collection's real critical potential.

A memoir's celebration of a life and criticism's analytical practice are different literary activities. The volume must be evaluated while preserving that distinction. The idea of Arvind Thakur's authorial freedom can succeed

only if readers, too, are free to interpret his writings independently, dissentingly, and on the basis of evidence. In this sense, the significance of the title Swatantracheta resides more in the critical disagreement preserved in the book than in the editor's declared image of the writer.

Reconsideration from the Perspective of Parallel Literary History

Mainstream literary histories frequently centre institutional awards, textbooks, and widely publicised works. Regional magazines, correspondence, informal literary associations, local publications, and little-discussed debates over genre are left on the margins. Swatantracheta, developed from a special issue of Videha, provides a useful resistance to this neglect. It documents not only the writer's works but also the small and large communities of criticism that took shape around them.

Yet the claim to a parallel history does not in itself confer authenticity. What makes it distinctive is the identification of sources, the preservation of dissenting evidence, the clarity of publication chronology, and comparative evaluation of local voices. By these standards, Swatantracheta is an important beginning, not a definitive biography. The differences in textual selection between the magazine and book, the absence of some original writings, the uneven depth of the criticism, and the personal character of the autobiographical statement mean that subsequent research will need to prepare separate collections of texts and reliable publication records.

The book demonstrates that literary history is not merely a catalogue of works but a dynamic interrelation of texts, readers, disputes, social memory, and editorial decisions. If this approach is developed further, the people's language of the Kosi region, the representation of marginalised experience, magazine-based debate, and generic innovation can receive a more balanced place in Maithili literary history.

Overall Judgement: Achievements, Limitations, and Subsequent Research

Swatantracheta's first achievement is to assemble a range of assessments of the relationships among the writer's fiction, poetry, ghazals, social thinking, and personality. Its second is to allow ideological agreement and formal disagreement to test rather than cancel each other. Its third is to make visible the relationship between everyday life in the Kosi region and the Maithili literary public sphere. Its fourth is to bring together criticism of fiction, reminiscences, and autobiographical statements within a multilayered exploration of literary biography.

Its limitations also warrant consideration. The contributors do not follow a common critical method; in several essays judgements are emotional; formal subtleties are sometimes overshadowed by the ideological aims of the fiction; and the writer's independent thinking receives relatively little representation. The absence of the complete original works also increases the reader's

dependence on critical interpretation. Under these circumstances the volume is better regarded as a reasoned collection of evidence than as the final word.

Essential tasks for future research include comparison of editions of the story collections, compilation of a glossary of folk vocabulary in the poetry, metrical analysis of the ghazals in Bahurupiya Pradesh Me, examination of textual differences between the Videha special issue and the printed volume, and independent editing of the writer's critical prose. Such studies could develop comparative frameworks for female autonomy, caste and political identity, memories of communal violence, the agrarian economy, and regional linguistic rights.

Ultimately, Swatantracheta is meaningful because it presents a literary personality not merely through institutional prestige but through embattled words, critical disagreement, and intimate recollection. The proper way to read the collection is to preserve both respect for the author and independence of judgement. Its enduring value for Maithili literary history lies in the possibility of an open, verifiable, and polyphonic reading.

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The references below are organised around the original collection, the essays it contains, and contemporary publications available in Videha. Different forms of the same book or essay should be read as distinct textual witnesses.

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REVIEW 3

EIGHTY-TWO SELECTED STORIES BY GAJENDRA THAKUR

A Narrative Rereading of Archives, Identity, and Everyday Life

Primary Text: Gajendra Thakurak 82 Ta Chayanit Katha (Eighty-Two Selected Stories by Gajendra Thakur)

Original Author: Gajendra Thakur · Selection and Editing: Ashish Anchinhar · Videha, 2026

Abstract

A study of Gajendra Thakur's eighty-two selected stories discloses a distinctive expansion of the Maithili fictional world. Alongside traditional village life, family relationships, and caste structures, institutions such as archives, courts, schools, hospitals, panchayats, construction sites, labour registers, and modern communications enter into and transform one another. The author's central narrative question is not whose statement constitutes the final truth, but how claims to truth are made among different human beings, documents, memories, and institutions. This study offers separate concise interpretations of all eighty-two stories drawn from ten source books or volumes, detailed close readings of representative stories, an examination of narrative craft and linguistic organisation, criticism of the method of selection, and a consideration of comparative relationships with the Maithili fictional tradition. Its conclusion is that the collection's distinctive achievement lies in transforming the discourse of rights from ideological declaration into the subtle drama of everyday objects, numbers, bodies, voices, and evidence. At the same time, excessive procedural detail and the recurrence of certain symbols in some narratives raise critical questions.

Keywords: Maithili fiction; Gajendra Thakur; archive; memory; caste; labour; institutional violence; female identity; folk language; narrative craft; literary history.

Sources of the Study and Its Critical Perspective

The principal basis of this study is the available edited text of Gajendra Thakur's "Eighty-Two Selected Stories." According to the publication information, Ashish Anchinhar selected the stories from ten source books or

volumes. Five come from Parvat Upar Bhamra Je Sutal, ten from Smritik Dosar Dis, five from Ijot—Janam-Janamk Katha, thirty from the three volumes of Katha-Shatatrayi, thirty from the three volumes of Katha-Tridhara, and two from Nav Pankhi. The organisation of the collection thus becomes a critical argument in itself: from earlier social satire to the incompleteness of memory, and thence to the minute experiences of institutional life.

In textual analysis, the explicitly stated actions and circumstances of the characters are distinguished from critical inference. Where a story withholds a final judgement, no artificial resolution has been added. The quoted lines have been checked against the wording of the available selected Devanagari text; no definitive claim has been made concerning variants among editions of the original source books. Quotations are identified by story title, in order to preserve the difference between interpretation and the source's own statements.

Throughout these texts, distinctions among "the original," "memory," and "correction" recur. The critical method also accepts these distinctions: literary truth is often not equivalent to a legal verdict; a character's words are not necessarily the author's final opinion; and an edited selection is not a complete substitute for an author's entire work. Accordingly, the evaluation considers narrative construction, the narrator's distance, the selection of detail, the development of symbols, and the function of silence separately.

An Integrated Literary Review: The Aesthetic Structures of Ten Source Groups

Parvat Upar Bhamra Je Sutal: Satire, Caste, and the Public Testing of Knowledge

In "Siddha Mahavir," the building of a temple by Anmana Didi and a family dispute over land together expose financial gain hidden beneath religious prestige and a crisis of trust. Once a name is entered on a document, the woman whose efforts preserved the sacred land is herself denied access to it. The satire is especially sharp where a later collective interpretation in terms of miracle collides with Anmana Didi's medical explanation. The narrative allows the reader to observe two systems of social explanation applied to the same event.

"Doma, Budhan and..." is not merely a tale of goodwill opposed to caste prejudice. Migration to Chandigarh, education, untouchability at communal feasts, and the professional advancement of the next generation are woven into the social history of one family. The narrator's faulty memory and extended ideological conversations complicate any unequivocal portrayal of progress. "Shabdashastram" raises questions of ownership over meaning through palm-leaf manuscripts, textual interpretation, and philosophical disagreement. Its many references to classical learning enrich the art while demanding additional patience from the reader.

"The Village of Mahisbar Brahmins" is primarily descriptive. Ponds, varieties of paddy, caste identities, and a wealth of local practices create its social geography. The extremely brief protest offered by "Caste and Caste" appears as a compressed, forceful counterpart to this extensive account of communal life. On one side stand the multiple layers of social identity, and on the other the unequal freedom to declare one's caste publicly: this tension creates the moral structure of the group of stories.

"Remove this very superstition from my mind." — "Siddha Mahavir"

"Caste and the caste system are two different things!" — "Doma, Budhan and..."

"Can I beat my chest and say that I am a Dom?" — "Caste and Caste"

Smritik Dosar Dis: Remembrance, Incomplete Texts, and the Politics of Evidence

The narrative centre of "The Copyist" is an empty bracket: Sudhindra must choose between the temptation to produce a beautiful, readable copy and the duty to preserve uncertainty about the original text. Here, silence is not a defect but an expression of intellectual integrity. "The Last Reader" begins with a public library destroyed by fire and opens the risky possibility of reconstructing books from memory. Popular recollection cannot fully replace the lost collection, but it may become a source of new literature.

"The Bullet at the Border" presents a multilayered structure of evidence. A boundary stone, a soldier's warning, an observer's position, the identification of an object, and translated experience all exist as different forms of testimony. The absence of a single omniscient judgement makes it an important instance of contemporary documentary narrative practice. "The Mason's Fall" raises a severe question about the relationship between an institution and its workers through the gap between safety instructions and the resources actually provided at a worksite.

"Kajal," "The Sisters," and "House Number Five" offer different structures of female experience: a conversation between generations about the meaning of adornment, the distance created by memories of sisterhood, and time deposited in the architecture of a home. In "The Dried-Up Kamala" and "The Smell of Earth," the geography of soil and river is transformed into private memory and the uncertain experience of migration. "The Music Teacher" examines institutional equality and inequality between school and skill centre through voice and silence.

"What had not been written was the most accurate copy." — "The Copyist"

"In the end, an author too becomes the reader of his own writing." — "The Last Reader"

"'I did not hear' must not be turned into 'he did not speak.'" — "The Bullet at the Border"

"He had asked them to change the rope above." — "The Mason's Fall"

Ijot—Janam-Janamk Katha: Lineage, Musical Tradition, and the Open Horizon of Choice

"Maternal Lineage" changes the meaning of a command imposed upon the eldest daughter through genealogy and inheritance, turning it into a means of "access to home." In "Raga," the collective processes of listening, seeking permission, and singing again matter more than any one person's ownership of a musical tradition. In "The Court," the discipline of testimony through questions and answers becomes part of the craft itself: time, water, old maps, and signs of use combine to make judgement difficult.

In "Dum," a flood, a missing person, and uncertainty about the date of death leave a long-lasting impact on domestic life. "Videha" insists on clear distinctions between genealogical lists, proof of property rights, and the preservation of memory. At the end of this group, a blank editorial page offers not an instruction but the possibility of a future writer. For that reason, "light" in Ijot is not a triumphant metaphor of victory; it is a modest, shared illumination amid incompleteness.

> *"The arrogance of the original was gone." — "Maternal Lineage"*

> *"No claim to property, caste, inheritance, or legal proof." — "Videha"*

Katha-Shatatrayi, Volume I: Bodies, Objects, and Invisible Characters

The brief message in "Two Letters," the insistence on the present face in "Photo Studio," the redistribution of use in "A Pair of Shoes," and the shared public place of "Divided Shade": ordinary objects and minor acts provide the decisive links in these stories. "The Other Door" exposes a subtle division among people considered eligible to enter a hospital. "A Seven-Minute Voice" attempts to make the distance between relationships audible through a measured sound.

"The Unfinished Play" links incomplete preparations for the stage to unresolved relationships in life. "The Thirty-First Bed" concerns an additional human need caught in the arithmetic of shelter; "The Brick Mark" concerns recognition of the craftsperson's labour; and "Outside the Count" concerns a resident invisible in the forms used to record loss. All three reveal the tension between the limits of enumeration and the existence of embodied people. The volume's strength lies in bringing debates about duty and compassion down from abstract exhortation to the material ground of beds, bricks, and registers.

> *"The register was now leaving behind the outlines of the people living inside it as well." — "Outside the Count"*

Katha-Shatatrayi, Volume II: Fields, Food, Labour, and Mutuality

"Across the Embankment" raises questions about the location of a shrine and collective identity after displacement. "The Voice of the Land" exposes the local politics of paths and boundaries. The motor of the "Sewing Machine" is not merely a device; it makes audible a new rhythm of independent work and family negotiation.

"Ten Kilograms of Rice" reveals subtle connections among weighing, a receipt, and the language of entitlement. "The Unfinished Song" rejects an individual's claim to ownership of a folk song in favour of collective memory. "The Earthen Flute" joins the patience of making an object to a child's curiosity. "The Open Door" reveals fear alongside opportunity, and "Silent Testimony" considers the meaning of being unable to speak in the pursuit of justice. "Kurthi Lentils" concerns the food chain and unequal exchange in the market; "A Dream of One Bigha" brings together the measurement of land and a worker's desire to cultivate a field of his own.

> *"The song belonged to the field. Whoever gave it voice, it became theirs." — "The Unfinished Song"*

Katha-Shatatrayi, Volume III: The Class Character of Public Space

"The Empty Bag" and "The Boat Remained Tied" turn disaster into stories of objects, transport, and collective dependence. "The Keeper of the Pond" begins with the responsibility for public water and encounters competing claims upon its use. "The Dom's Flute" brings caste-based devaluation into the payment register of a ceremonial event. Listening to an artist's music and granting fair value to his labour are two distinct steps.

The village shade and paper enumeration in "The Register Beneath the Banyan Tree"; the seating arrangements in "The Caste Chair"; housing insecurity in "The Tenant Girl"; a woman's economic prudence in "Secret Savings"; seen and unseen routes in "The Station That Is Not on the Map"; and the displacement of memory in "A Stranger in One's Own Home"—all show how the boundaries of private life are continually redrawn by public arrangements.

> *"Local solo performer—Chandeshwar Dom—flute—five hundred rupees." — "The Dom's Flute"*

> *"Chair twenty-eight. Permanent place—none." — "The Caste Chair"*

Katha-Tridhara, Volume I: Sound, the Wrong Word, and the Effects of Documents

The inactive instrument in "The Bell That Would Not Ring" carries a home's silent history. "The Reverse Route" contrasts the straight line with the lived experience of walking. "The Blank Notebook" is an exercise in acknowledging multiple forms of knowledge; "One Wrong Word" reveals how a single word can break relationships. "Before the Lamp Goes Out" reconstructs a personal path within a shared boundary.

"The Night Boat" sharpens the moral choices of disaster; "Not a Leader Who Forgets Names, but a Teacher" questions the relationship between responsibility for pupils and the frailty of memory. "The River's Papers" recounts people invisible on maps; "The Sand Landing" measures the consumption of natural resources; and "The Power of a Signature" examines the actual meaning of the written consent of a women's collective. In this volume, paper is more than a ledger: it is a point of entry into decisions.

"From today I shall not give numbers to my answers." — "The Blank Notebook"

Katha-Tridhara, Volume II: Forms, Stamps, and Invisible Labour

"The Night on the Raised Platform" presents the incomplete accounting of night watch. "The Returning Stamp" is the story of truth made from half an impression. "Chair Number Zero in the Waiting Room" introduces an outsider's need into institutional regulations. In "The Empty Date Box," the date entered on an official form to secure assistance gradually changes a person's memory; the story subtly discloses the effect of bureaucratic language on remembrance.

"The Original Page of the Corrections Register" preserves the history of an erroneous entry instead of erasing it. The meal order in "Three Empty Chairs" makes the places of absent people visible. "The Veranda Bulb" reveals the politics of relationships in the distribution of a small domestic light; "One Cup of Tea Less," a mysterious relation between calculation and affection; "The Bamboo Bridge," the restoration of communication broken during work; and "The Ruined Field Boundary," cooperation after quarrelling through the practices of agriculture.

"Yet in people's speech it was still chair number zero." — "Chair Number Zero in the Waiting Room"

"Tell me the date that will be accepted on paper." — "The Empty Date Box"

"The original is history; a correction is the next line of history." — "The Original Page of the Corrections Register"

Katha-Tridhara, Volume III: The Ethical Richness of Unanswered Questions

"School Shoes" joins a deprived girl's journey to school with her family's determination to preserve seed for cultivation. "The Panchayat Tap" raises questions of unequal access to water among neighbourhoods. In "Wages," the refusal to let a remaining fifty rupees disappear from the brick-kiln account becomes a small but tangible victory for labour. "The Little Teacher" imagines educational responsibility not as a teacher's possession of answers but as a child's willingness to listen to questions. "Seven Steps" concerns the counting of memory and psychological disturbance.

"Autobiography of a File" makes a government file its narrator and constructs a moral satire of departmental delay. "The Boundary" contrasts the ease of administrative classification with the continuity of fields and water. "The Veranda Bulb" in this volume is different from the story of the same title in the previous volume: here Anima's domestic veranda becomes a place organised by the timing of work. "The Endless Register" prevents a genealogical list from governing an unborn future. "The Library of Mithila" cultivates the discipline of accepting limited, verifiable evidence instead of the alluring fantasy of a rare book.

"Fifty was not a very large number. But for the first time it had not disappeared anywhere." — "Wages"

"The paper travels so that responsibility can be passed downwards." — "Autobiography of a File"

"The next life has not yet been written." — "The Endless Register"

"Where the sources do not agree with one another." — "The Library of Mithila"

Nav Pankhi: Adolescent Vision, Dignity, and a Shared Inheritance

"Life on Crutches" refuses to turn physical disability into a display of pity. The right to choose a life partner, the propriety of asking questions, and the imagination of an independent future teach the reader an ethics grounded in natural character interaction. "The Book Saved from the Flood" connects the preservation of collective memory to an adventurous event through a book rescued from rising water. Having survived the disaster, the book is no longer merely an object but a bridge between generations.

Both stories for adolescents matter to adult readers as well. The first changes perspectives on individual dignity; the second turns the duty of preserving knowledge into a communal act. To place them at the end is not merely to distinguish age groups but to extend the collection's ethical thread into the next generation.

"Life may be on crutches; dreams are not." — "Life on Crutches"

"Some stains are not simply damage; they are reminders too." — "The Book Saved from the Flood"

Separate Close Readings: The Creative Structure of Representative Stories

"Siddha Mahavir": The Irony of Popular Narration and the Economy of Religion

Anmana Didi's apparent simplicity in this story is not a moral weakness. The woman who sells her own grain to support the building of a temple and respect the dignity of labour cannot grasp the intricacies of legal documents; she trusts the religious language employed by her nephew and Dasji. The decisive turn of the plot is not the transfer of a share of land, but the closing of a path. The implication is that a name on a property deed and the right to use property are distinct things.

At the close, the nephew's death receives two interpretations: one miraculous, the other medical. The author brings these opposing meanings face to face without imposing a supernatural verdict upon the event. The word siddha thus becomes the ironic centre of the story's meaning.

"Caste and Caste": The Explosive Force of One Question in a Seed-Story

It would be a mistake to regard this as a trivial incident merely because of its brevity. A short dialogue brings together the equal rank of two senior officials, their shared social environment, and their unequal freedom to

identify themselves. "No one will say anything" ceases to be a sentence of empty bravado and becomes the one-sided capacity to claim social protection.

The story does not select a "good" character for the reader. Permission and prohibition within language become the event themselves. This is a useful demonstration of the compressive possibilities of the Maithili seed-story.

"The Copyist": The Gravity of an Unfilled Bracket

Sudhindra's professional skill lies in making letters legible. The story does not reject that skill; it shows its limit, the point beyond which the writer wants the text to acknowledge that the original remains unknowable. The pressure of an exhibition seeks to make the text "readable," while the blurred traces of damaged letters are historical facts.

Here the blank space is both an artistic image and a principle of textual criticism. Refusing to fill it does not imply indecision; it is an active responsibility exercised against the temptation to guess.

"The Bullet at the Border": An Unresolved Judgement Among Multiple Witnesses

A single shot is fired in the story, but the narrator does not convert it into an endless series of verdicts. Hearing a sound, giving a statement, measuring distance, and recognising danger belong to different levels of action. Such discrimination between fact and meaning assumes the form of scrutiny of legal evidence.

Because the narrative is constructed from the limited perspectives of several observers, the final sentence, "The sound of the bullet lasted a moment," confronts an extended social memory. Feeling does not replace fact in this structure.

"The Dried-Up Kamala": A River's Dialogue with an Absent Listener

The narrator continues speaking to Gopi. Although the addressee is absent, that person remains the ethical centre of the story. The dried-up channel is not simply a natural description but a map of the varied relations people have with memory.

The refusal to "put my voice in place of yours" is the narrator's most decisive recognition of limits. Being able to make a story out of a loved one's memory is different from declaring it the final truth.

"Maternal Lineage" and "The Endless Register": From Inheritance to an Autonomous Life

In both stories genealogical records are an essential cultural inheritance yet become questionable when turned into commands governing the future. In "Maternal Lineage," the meaning of the house key entrusted to the eldest daughter changes, transforming an obligation into a means of access.

The final postponement in "The Endless Register"—the child's name will be decided later—does not erase genealogical continuity; it sets a limit to its

authority before the unwritten life of a new person. Both stories offer models of ethical agreement between social memory and individual desire.

"The Dom's Flute" and "The Caste Chair": The Material Language of Equality

In "The Dom's Flute," appreciation of the music is not enough: the artist's name and remuneration must be recorded in the event register. Such economic acknowledgement brings questions of art and caste together.

In "The Caste Chair," the preordained position of a chair reproduces an arrangement even without any written caste rule. Moving the chair changes a social sign. Both narratives make the discourse of rights tangible at the level of objects.

"The Empty Date Box" and "The Original Page of the Corrections Register": The Temporal Authority of Paper

Floodwater destroys different parts of a house on different days, while an assistance form demands a single official date. Gradually, the phrase "the date accepted on paper" enters the household's memory of events. The story subtly demonstrates how standardisation, though necessary for government assistance, can constrict the history of lived experience.

"The Original Page of the Corrections Register" opens up the opposite possibility: rather than erasing an error, it preserves a visible record of the error and its correction. The two stories offer reciprocal criticism of the power of evidence and its risks.

"Autobiography of a File": The Object as Narrator

The file itself recounts its birth and its passage through government departments. Where official papers appear to stand guard over human rights, the speaking file takes readers inside the historical machinery of administrative delay. The repair of a broken bridge becomes the beginning of another new file.

This repetition constitutes the narrative's satire: the problem continues through real time while the paper moves upwards through an official hierarchy. Personification is the fundamental device of the narrative, carried through to its final ethical effect.

"The Library of Mithila": From the Temptation of an All-Encompassing Collection to Evidentiary Modesty

Ishan encounters the possibility of an unimaginable accumulation of knowledge, but the work does not celebrate an infinite literary treasury. At the end he considers merely three files, four audio notes, two maps, and one unfinished question sufficient.

Keeping discordant sources independent rather than forcing them into a single narrative is this story's distinctive achievement. The imaginative enterprise of historiography is here subjected to critical restraint.

"Life on Crutches": Restoring Dignity Against the Pity of Compassion

The title and setting refer to physical support, but the text centres on autonomous choice concerning the future. A character's refusal to become an object of pity in matters of marriage is itself an assertion of dignity.

The closing sentence remains memorable because it does not deny bodily limitations; instead, it refuses to imprison life's possibilities within those limitations.

"The Book Saved from the Flood": From a Rescued Object to Communal Memory

The adolescent protagonist's active awareness of risk and the collective cooperation through which a book is rescued are more than an instructive message. Stains on the waterlogged book become the marks of its physical journey and the memory of disaster.

The book placed on a high library shelf passes the village's history into the hands of a new generation. This conclusion gives the entire selection's discussion of archives and memory a readable and hopeful ending.

Separate Concise Analyses of All Eighty-Two Stories

The following annotations identify the narrative action, principal symbol, and critical question of each work separately. Two distinct stories with the same title are identified according to their respective source volumes.

Parvat Upar Bhamra Je Sutal

01. "Siddha Mahavir" — Anmana Didi's religious labour, her nephew's manipulations of property, and the two explanations of a supposed miracle prevent faith from being exempted from questioning.

02. "Doma, Budhan and..." — Budhan's labour as a migrant and Doma's education constitute the extended social time of caste mobility; dialogue repeatedly returns to the central question.

03. "Shabdashastram" — Palm-leaf manuscripts and a philosophical debate over meaning turn questions of textual knowledge, ownership, and traditional interpretative authority into drama.

04. "The Village of Mahisbar Brahmins" — The extensive portrayal of ponds, rice, caste neighbourhoods, and people who narrate village life makes the village not a single community but a plural geography of intersecting interests.

05. "Caste and Caste" — An exceedingly brief conversation exposes the sharp inequality between equal official rank and the public right to identify one's caste.

Smritik Dosar Dis

06. "The Copyist" — Sudhindra's empty bracket reveals the ethics of textual editing and the potential deception of a tidy transcription.

07. “The Last Reader” — The burned library becomes an opportunity to begin reconstruction, but the risk of attempting to remake original books entirely from memory remains.

08. “The Bullet at the Border” — By distinguishing different forms of testimony concerning a boundary stone and a gunshot, the story preserves the differences among fear, intention, and action.

09. “The Mason's Fall” — The discrepancy between a construction site's safety belt and its inadequate rope carries the accident beyond a simple explanation in terms of personal error.

10. “Kajal” — A grandmother's application of kajal opens an intergenerational conversation about self-presentation and socially approved images of women, beyond the question of adornment alone.

11. “The Dried-Up Kamala” — Addressing the absent Gopi, the narrator acknowledges the limits of his own account between the river's former course and private memory.

12. “The Smell of Earth” — The first rainfall and the scent of the soil transform the distance between city and village into an embodied experience of remembrance.

13. “The Sisters” — The sisterhood of Mridula and Neera, stretched across many years, becomes a form of incomplete reconciliation through an unfinished line.

14. “House Number Five” — An old window and changing residents raise questions about the anonymous memory of place and the ownership claimed by successive generations.

15. “The Music Teacher” — Parallel episodes involving vocational examinations and musical recollection link skill, equal opportunity, and the remnants of an old melody.

Ijot—Janam-Janamk Katha

16. “Maternal Lineage” — The house entrusted to the eldest daughter threatens to burden her autonomy; the key becomes not a command but the possibility of return.

17. “Raga” — A song at the river landing and its recording raise the ethics of collective ownership, permission, and the reproduction of folk melodies.

18. “The Court” — Questions and answers in testimony keep open different layers of the river, boundary markers, and human memory.

19. “Dum” — The uncertain chronology of someone lost in a disaster reveals the presence of unfinished grief in everyday domestic conduct.

20. “Videha” — The insistence that gaps in a genealogical record should not become proof of entitlement, and the blank editorial page, open memory to a shared future.

Katha-Shatatrayi, Volume I

21. “Two Letters” — Three umbrellas in a home and a brief note form an intensely private image of the unspoken distance between people.

22. “Photo Studio” — An elderly woman wants her portrait with her present spectacles and facial marks; photography becomes a fixed moment of self-determination.

23. “A Pair of Shoes” — Shoes are not merely an object of charity, but a sign of practical cooperation that circulates through use to the next person in need.

24. “Divided Shade” — Shade shared by neighbouring street vendors brings private competition and cooperative conduct together in public space.

25. “The Other Door” — The two entrances to a health centre are the invisible language of administrative division; entering through the wrong one becomes a concrete test of rights.

26. “A Seven-Minute Voice” — The seven-minute limit contains distinctive rhythms of sound, home, and relationships separated by distance.

27. “The Unfinished Play” — A stage curtain that sticks and an incomplete performance form parallels with unresolved questions in human relationships.

28. “The Thirty-First Bed” — The thirty beds allotted to a women's shelter are shown to be an inadequate number when a thirty-first human being needs refuge.

29. “The Brick Mark” — A small marking on a brick carries both the record and the anonymity of a team of workers.

30. “Outside the Count” — A flood-damage form cannot include all the residents of a building under a single household name.

Katha-Shatatrayi, Volume II

31. “Across the Embankment” — The dispute over a shrine's location in a displaced village rests upon a collision between geography and collective sacredness.

32. “The Voice of the Land” — A path six hands wide and an old stone turn the land's supposed silence into a dispute over rights.

33. “The Sewing Machine” — A new motor fitted to an old sewing machine changes a working woman's income and role within the household.

34. “Ten Kilograms of Rice” — Weighing ten kilograms of rice turns an official promise into a demand for direct verification on the scale.

35. “The Unfinished Song” — An incomplete folk song passes from voice to voice; ownership disperses into collective labour rather than belonging to one name.

36. “The Earthen Flute” — A potter's wheel and a child's half-fired clay become symbols of the proper time needed to acquire a skill.

37. “The Open Door” — An open gate is not merely an opportunity to go outside; it also conveys a woman's hesitation and the difficult rhythm of a household's acceptance.

38. “Silent Testimony” — Silence in court signifies not only an inability to speak but also independent dignity and the limitations of testimony.

39. “Kurthi Lentils” — Domestic hunger for kurthi, madua, and rice is woven into the changing relationship between markets and farming.

40. “A Dream of One Bigha” — A rope twenty hands long and a field measuring one bigha provide a measure for a worker's limited, practical dream.

Katha-Shatatrayi, Volume III

41. “The Empty Bag” — An empty bag hanging from a peg remains as a trace of deprivation and the unfinished struggle for livelihood.

42. “The Boat Remained Tied” — The knot securing a boat is a concrete symbol of a decision left unresolved between disaster and relationships.

43. “The Keeper of the Pond” — The keeper's daily conduct raises a question about ownership versus stewardship of a collective resource.

44. “The Dom's Flute” — Payment recorded in the Dom musician's own name registers cultural equality within economic accounts.

45. “The Register Beneath the Banyan Tree” — The register beside the banyan's shade tests the criteria governing the distribution of public benefits.

46. “The Caste Chair” — An old caste-based seating order breaks down; without a proclamation, practices surrounding space begin to change.

47. “The Tenant Girl” — A young woman's rented accommodation is negotiated between the limits of domestic space and insecure urban relationships.

48. “Secret Savings” — Malati Devi's concealed savings reveal both the invisibility of domestic economic labour and her independent judgement.

49. “The Station That Is Not on the Map” — A station absent from the map exposes the incompleteness of facts between personal perspective and memories of travel.

50. “A Stranger in One's Own Home” — The experience of returning home yet feeling estranged is an uneasy narrative about memory, household objects, and altered relationships.

Katha-Tridhara, Volume I

51. “The Bell That Would Not Ring” — A bell that remains silent becomes a concrete, mute remnant of an unanswered call amid repairs to a house.

52. “The Reverse Route” — The contrast between a straight, measured path and the bends of human experience discloses the limitations of modern maps.

53. “The Blank Notebook” — The empty notebook relinquishes the teacher's certainty of answers and acknowledges the many possibilities of a question.

54. “One Wrong Word” — A single mispronounced word exposes a complicated reckoning involving assistance, debt, and family affection.

55. “Before the Lamp Goes Out” — Crossing a line in the courtyard before the lamp is extinguished creates an autonomous passage within the home.

56. “The Night Boat” — The decision about whom the boat will carry first on a flood-stricken night becomes a test of ethics in crisis.

57. “Not a Leader Who Forgets Names, but a Teacher” — The story of a teacher who forgets names produces an engaging yet difficult tension between memory and moral responsibility.

58. “The River's Papers” — The documents relating to a river make settlements omitted from registration and older maps visible through a new survey.

59. “The Sand Landing” — The clarity of the water and a knot in a rope become two measures for accounting for natural resources at a sand landing.

60. “The Power of a Signature” — The signatures of a women's savings collective become not a mere formality of consent but a right to inspect the complete file.

Katha-Tridhara, Volume II

61. “The Night on the Raised Platform” — Night watch on the platform and a blank register create unequal accounts of the collective time of risk.

62. “The Returning Stamp” — Half a stamp cannot stand as the shadow of complete proof; human reasoning must complete the unfinished circle.

63. “Chair Number Zero in the Waiting Room” — A chair numbered zero in a hospital gives rise to a need excluded from official forms and prompts a new preliminary examination of institutional priorities.

64. “The Empty Date Box” — The compulsory date on a flood-relief application overlays memories of events and establishes an official date as though it were private truth.

65. “The Original Page of the Corrections Register” — Preserving the history of correction rather than crossing out an original account signals responsibility towards law, time, and error.

66. “Three Empty Chairs” — Three vacant dining chairs acquire meaning through the dignity of absent people and gaps in the names recorded on paper.

67. “The Veranda Bulb” — In the first veranda story, a twelve-watt bulb forms a miniature metaphor for the distribution of shared domestic space.

68. “One Cup of Tea Less” — A household record of one fewer cup of tea points towards calculation, waiting, and an unspoken everyday relationship.

69. “The Bamboo Bridge” — Neighbours' silence breaks on a bamboo bridge; the act of cooperation becomes the first word of communication.

70. “The Ruined Field Boundary” — Despite preserving a history of conflict, the damaged boundary opens an opportunity for shared access to water in everyday cultivation.

Katha-Tridhara, Volume III

71. “School Shoes” — Sarita's shoes and the seeds preserved by her father at home represent two kinds of investment in education and the future.

72. “The Panchayat Tap” — The public tap becomes a stringent test of whose time and access count as rights to a common facility.

73. “Wages” — The “remaining fifty” in a brick-kiln account makes a worker's invisible wages visible in the ledger, despite the small amount.

74. “The Little Teacher” — Instead of providing ready answers, the child acting as teacher begins to listen to the different answers of classmates.

75. “Seven Steps” — Seven steps at a printing press become a story about the disjunction between memory and the body's act of counting.

76. “Autobiography of a File” — Speaking in the first person, the file recounts its movement and reveals the absurdity of departmental delays and repeated applications for repairs.

77. “The Boundary” — The administration draws a border while water continues to flow without stopping; the material world challenges the conditions of classification.

78. “The Veranda Bulb” — In the second story bearing this title, Anima's veranda where she sews becomes a public statement of income and working hours.

79. “The Endless Register” — An unwritten life imposes an ethical limit upon the register's claim to name a newborn child.

80. “The Library of Mithila” — Rejecting the possibility of a miraculous repository in favour of accepting disagreements within limited records constitutes a discipline of historical writing.

Nav Pankhi

81. “Life on Crutches” — Pity cannot claim authority over the future of a young man who walks with crutches; freedom to dream is affirmed.

82. “The Book Saved from the Flood” — Stains on a book rescued from water become physical marks of communal memory handed down to the next generation.

Comparative Discussion of Language, Form, and the Treatment of Evidence

Transformations of the Narrator and the Multiple Layers of Time

The dialogue-centred folk narrator who intervenes in the tale is visible in "Siddha Mahavir" and "Doma, Budhan and..." from the first source group. The letter-like address of "The Dried-Up Kamala," the questions and answers of "The Court," the speaking object of "Autobiography of a File," the personal memory-narrator of "Seven Steps," and the critical investigator of "The Library of Mithila" all create different narrative roles. It would therefore be unjust to readers to impose a single "authorial voice" upon all the stories.

Time in many instances is not merely the line along which events unfold. In "The Empty Date Box," an official date changes past experience; in "The Sisters," a separation of forty years alters the meaning of a line; and in "The Endless Register," written ancestral names do not acquire control over a newborn child's future. Time remains active in these stories as a triangle of memory, document, and present decision.

The Sensibility of Objects and the Structure of Small Metaphors

Shoes, chairs, beds, light bulbs, tea, weighing scales, registers, maps, boats, flutes, and keys are recurring objects in the fictional world. They are not merely decorative symbols, because their use advances events. In "The Caste Chair," moving the chair alters the effect of an intangible caste distinction; in "Wages," refusing to erase fifty rupees intervenes in economic relations; and in "The Book Saved from the Flood," the preservation of stains preserves cultural memory.

Nevertheless, the recurrence of this object-centred method sometimes allows the reader to anticipate the ending. In some stories, the force of a small suggestion is exceptionally sharp; in others, the final symbolic statement concerning an object is made a little too explicit. This variation should be treated as a genuine criterion for evaluating quality.

Institutional Vocabulary and the Possibilities of Maithili Prose

Words such as "rule," "order," "signature," "original," "correction," "evidence," "item," "form," "weight," and "sequence" are used in such a way that experiences of labour and rights emerge through the narrative language itself. As a result, office life is no longer an unimaginable external geography for Maithili fiction. Language brings the verifiability of conduct and the structure of entitlement inside the plot.

Conversely, the folk descriptions of "The Village of Mahisbar Brahmins," the vocal tradition of "The Unfinished Song," the inward memoiristic voice of "The Dried-Up Kamala," and the lyrical world of the artist in "The Dom's Flute" prevent the language from becoming a dry bureaucratic idiom. The critical challenge is to establish the proportions of these two linguistic currents.

Social Justice: Procedure Rather Than Declaration

Caste-based disregard takes four different forms in “Caste and Caste,” “The Dom's Flute,” “The Caste Chair,” and “Doma, Budhan and…”: the courage to speak, payment to an artist, a place to sit, and mobility through education. Equality is consequently not only an ideology but also a means of transforming everyday conduct.

The women of “Kajal,” “Maternal Lineage,” “Secret Savings,” “The Power of a Signature,” “The Other Door,” and “The Veranda Bulb” are not passive objects of pity. They are agents of identity, income, consent, and choice. Yet victories in these compassionate social endings are generally limited. Awareness of such limits prevents the narratives from becoming simplified celebrations of triumph.

Comparative Position in Maithili Literary History

The descriptive qualities of earlier Maithili prose and modern social fiction are not simply two endpoints of a single straight developmental line. Traditions of detailed information about folk life, the questioning impulse of satire, the realities of rural labour, unstable urban sociability, and the compression of meaning in seed-stories continue to act as separate currents within contemporary writing. The collection's distinctive feature is its convergence of these currents in struggles over archives, forms, and public resources.

A thematic dialogue may be perceived between the rural labour and social inequality of Yatri's Balchanma and “Wages,” “Kurthi Lentils,” and “Doma, Budhan and…”. Yet that novel and the stories in this collection differ in historical moment, narrative extent, and the organisation of the narrative voice. Shared subjects do not in themselves prove influence. Rather, the comparison should illuminate changed literary forms for depicting rural class experience.

The questioning of the commerce of faith in “Siddha Mahavir” and the verbal reversal of “Caste and Caste” bear critical affinities with Harimohan Jha's satirical tradition. Nevertheless, the satire here does not generally conclude with a single witty resolution but leaves an institutional outcome unsettled. Comparison of “A Stranger in One's Own Home,” “One Wrong Word,” and “Seven Steps” with the disintegration of modern human experience in Rajkamal Chaudhary's fiction is suggestive, but formal resemblance should not be presented as historical indebtedness without independent comparative study of the texts.

The rural writings of Jagdish Prasad Mandal share a field of concern with farming objects, divisions of labour, and social behaviour. But this selection by Gajendra Thakur has a distinct new centre in administrative files, registers, seals, and technical forms of proof. In relation to the Maithili seed-story tradition associated with Munnaji, the brief impact of “Caste and Caste” and the object-narrator of “Autobiography of a File” may be regarded as two

extremes of generic variety. The purpose of comparison here is to understand traditions and possibilities, not to establish claims of imitation.

The Videha catalogues of books and research provide means of locating continually published sources. Yet the presence of a work in a catalogue alone is not definitive proof of its historical position or aesthetic value. Accordingly, the chief ground of this study's evaluation remains the stories as they appear in the collection; Videha's bibliographical information provides a context for literary history.

A Critique and Evaluation of the Editorial Selection

The clear separation of the ten source groups benefits readers. In particular, the two distinct stories titled "The Veranda Bulb" must be identified through their actual events despite appearing in different groups under the same title. The large number of stories gives readers ample opportunity to discover shared thematic threads. Yet drawing thirty stories each from the three volumes of two separate series also means that similarities of method within those series may have a disproportionate influence on any overall comparative judgement.

Formally, the collection's principal strengths include its multilayered treatment of evidence, its ability to generate large social meanings from small objects, its setting of limits to the rights characters may claim, and its avoidance of unnecessary verdicts at the end of a narrative. Weaknesses arise where extended descriptions of procedure slow the movement of emotional tension, particularly in dense classical debates or sequences of bureaucratic investigation. A second challenge is the recurrence of moral motifs: blank pages, incomplete signatures, remaining figures in an account, and silent endings can be extraordinarily effective, but their novelty may diminish when too many narratives with nearly identical arrangements stand together.

These reservations should not be misunderstood as objections to the works' social commitments. The literary question is which stories allow ethical awareness to arise from characters' actions, and where the explanation of meaning is delivered a little prematurely. "The Copyist," "The Bullet at the Border," "Maternal Lineage," "The Caste Chair," "The Empty Date Box," "The Endless Register," and "Life on Crutches" are comparatively distinctive because of their formal decisions and the experiences of their characters. "The Village of Mahisbar Brahmins" and "Shabdashastram" make different demands upon the reader: their descriptive and philosophical density requires standards other than those applied to a very brief story.

Conclusion

Gajendra Thakur's eighty-two selected stories do not merely seek to give Maithili literature new social subjects. They attempt to introduce new circumstances of evidence, disagreement, and justice into language and narrative form themselves. Caste hierarchy, women's autonomy, land rights, access to school, flooding, workers' unpaid wages, hospital priorities,

ownership of folk songs, and the uses of genealogical registers—all prompt the same questions: whose experiences were counted, whose names omitted, who was given the right to speak, and which documents exercise unnecessary authority over human lives?

A central achievement of these stories is their transformation of unresolved questions from a perceived weakness into an expression of critical integrity. The journey begins with Anmana Didi's rejection of superstition, preserves the distinction between memory and the original, records a labourer's fifty rupees, moves a chair, suspends the command to choose the next name in a genealogy, and finally places a flood-rescued book in the hands of the next generation. This is not a straightforward declaration of progress. It is a literary discipline concerned with discovering the possibility of justice in everyday decisions.

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REVIEW 4

THE EDITORIAL WRITINGS IN THE COMPLETE WORKS OF GAJENDRA THAKUR

Multigeneric Creativity, Evidence in Knowledge, and Parallel Literary History

Abstract

Ashish Anchinhar's Gajendra Thakur Samagrak Sampadakiya (Editorial Writings on the Complete Works of Gajendra Thakur) broadens the conventional boundaries of an author-centred critical book in Maithili, assuming the form of a multigeneric intellectual project. Its scope includes not only creative literature such as novels and stories but also drama, poetry, criticism, philosophy, history, genealogical treatises, grammar, lexical resources, children's literature, and translation in both directions. The central argument of this study is that the book is not merely a catalogue of writings or a laudatory introduction: it is an editorial endeavour situated between "evidence from the text" and "the social responsibility of evidence." Yet interpretation developed principally from titles, a uniform critical idiom, uneven depth of analysis across vast material, and the absence of sufficient comparative corroboration for wide-ranging claims about literary history invite scrutiny. This study uses close readings of the original editorial structure and representative review sections, selected quotations checked against the wording of the printed text, comparative consideration of ancient, medieval, and modern Maithili literary tendencies, and references to published research archives of Videha. The book is an important example of a Maithili literary institution examining itself; its enduring critical results will depend on systematic further examination of source registers, dissenting readings, and evidence from individual works.

Keywords: Gajendra Thakur; Ashish Anchinhar; Maithili criticism; editorial history; discernment of evidence; parallel literary history; genealogy; translation; children's literature; Videha.

Introduction: The Distinction Between a Writer's Total Output and an Editor's Perspective

The word samagra, or "complete works," often arouses an expectation of completeness and definitive judgement. Yet bringing an author's entire output into a single collection and establishing the totality of meaning in that output

are different undertakings. The first involves collection, classification, and archiving; the second calls for critical selection, comparative perspective, and dissent. What distinguishes Ashish Anchinhar's book is not that it entirely dissolves this division, but that it moves between the two sides. On one side lies the author's immense range of writing; on the other, the editor's methods of classification and evaluation. The question posed by the book is consequently not simply "What has been written?" but also "What conception of knowledge connects these diverse writings?"

The editor's introduction makes the following statement: "Folk knowledge and scholarship, memory and archives, the mother tongue and multilingual dialogue continually test one another." This is the principal critical seed of the collection. The relationship between folk knowledge and formal learning is understood as reciprocal testing rather than the one-way dissemination of "higher" knowledge. The relationship between memory and archives is not straightforward harmony either: memory brings feeling, forgetting, and society's silences, while archives provide dates, names, sequences, and means of examining claims. The tensions between the two recur in literature, history, and philosophy.

On this basis, the book's richest possibility lies in imagining a "parallel institution of reading." The writer produces works; the editor places them in an order determined by genre, question, and evidence; a periodical makes the arrangement public; and readers then challenge it. Editorial labour consequently becomes a primary operation in constructing literary history. Yet the construction of a history is not identical with establishing an authoritative historical account. How comprehensive is the included material, how independent are the critical conclusions, and which voices have been excluded? These three questions must remain open.

The Organisation of the Book and the Criteria of Study

The opening section contains an extended series of independent editorial observations organised by genre. It is followed by sectional lists of topics, a detailed contents, reviews of individual works, and a large accumulation of scholarly resources. The evident arrangement places novels, story collections, drama, verse, criticism, philosophy, history, genealogical records, grammar, thesauri, self-learning materials, and translations into separate divisions. Yet this classification serves more than the convenience of a library catalogue. It shows the reader how many media can express a single writer's view of society.

Four criteria are useful in assessing the editorial method: specificity in the selected text; the reasoning behind a critical judgement; evidence for comparisons with other works; and the distinction between authorial and editorial voices. According to these standards, some parts of the book are exceptionally fruitful, notably explicit discussion of the limitations of a novel about financial crime, attempts to identify repetition in the stories, archival caution in discussions of genealogical records, and the injunction not to invent plots from titles alone. Elsewhere, general praise, generic description,

and possible symbolic interpretations are more prominent. Such unevenness may be a natural problem of an extensive collection, but it must nevertheless be recognised as a critical problem.

The specific textual foundation of this study is the editorial book itself. Gajendra Thakur's original works are being discussed through Ashish Anchinhar's interpretation. Where the complete texts of their independent editions have not been examined directly, editorial judgements are not presented as verified facts about those originals. Quotations too are identified as belonging to the editorial volume, not as independent evidence from the novels or stories. This distinction preserves a necessary distance between an evaluation of the editorial work and a final verdict upon the author's entire creative world.

Separate Close Readings: Decisive Passages in the Editorial Language

Consider the linguistic construction of the introductory proposition that "Folk knowledge and scholarship, memory and archives, the mother tongue and multilingual dialogue continually test one another." Three pairs of nouns occur within a single syntactic pattern: "folk knowledge" beside "scholarship," "memory" beside "archives," and "mother tongue" beside "multilingual dialogue." This sequence is not a linear movement from outside to inside or from below to above; it creates an impression of dialectical equivalence. The final verb, "test," activates that equivalence. Placing so compact a proposition at the opening of the editorial work is not mere ornament: it anticipates the structure of the book's argument. Whether the principle is sustained with equal consistency in every section, however, requires separate examination.

"Criticism is literature's self-knowledge" is an unusually compressed proposition. "Self-knowledge" encompasses both self-acknowledgement and self-examination. If criticism merely proclaims the creator's importance, it performs only half the work of self-knowledge; if it also exposes the criteria by which its own institution makes selections, it approaches a fuller meaning. The proposition immediately following it—"Modern academic criticism does not merely deliver value judgements; it establishes methods of reading"—confirms this shift. The word "merely" signals enlargement rather than negation: evaluation has not been abandoned, but the method underlying it is to be made public.

The statement concerning genealogy—"What a document does not say is as important as what it says"—has a parallel structure that conceals a profound asymmetry. The first element concerns an existing record; the second, an absent and supposedly relevant fact. "As important" gives the two equal historical significance without conferring equal evidentiary status. The reliability of genealogical studies depends upon precisely this distinction. A gap is not a substitute for a conclusion; it marks the beginning of the next research question.

In a discussion of the social metaphors of prose, the rule "A plot cannot be invented from a title until its relationship with the actual events of the story is established" is an explicit prohibition. It is especially valuable here because the opening part of the collection frequently develops extended possibilities of meaning from the imagery of titles. In the light of this principle, such early readings of images should more fairly be understood as provisional interpretative proposals rather than final conclusions. This internal awareness of self-regulation allows the book itself to provide instruments for its own criticism.

In the discussion of translation, the contrasting statement "From the perspective of world literature, such translations make Maithili not a receiving language but a giving language" is important. By following "not" with "giving," it seeks to reverse the one-sided dependence of a mother tongue. Its underlying political meaning is a refusal of linguistic inferiority. Yet proper literary testing of the proposition requires comparative examples from translated texts, attention to their accessibility to target readers, and examination of changes in expression. The sentence specifies a goal; it does not itself prove the goal has been fully achieved.

These five textual passages show that the editorial language is strongest when it identifies the limits of evidence alongside its declarations. Continuity of argument will be established only when internal acknowledgement and specific literary examples jointly produce judgements throughout the book. Close linguistic reading, literary history, and social criticism therefore become complementary instruments, not substitutes for one another.

Narratives of Knowledge: An Expanded Model of the Novel

The editorial work proposes the formulation "narratives of knowledge" for the novels. This does not mean that philosophical instruction has simply replaced storytelling. More meaningfully, the sequence of events itself requires characters to gather evidence from concrete materials, test the reliability of memory, confront institutional power, and live with incomplete truth. The novelistic quality lies not in arriving easily at knowledge but in the drama of struggling to establish it.

The editorial reading of Sahasrabadhani rests on the interdependence of water, family, memory, and administration. Flooding is not merely weather or disaster but an arrangement of experience across generations. It is fruitful to read the river's recurring movements, recollections of forgotten places, migration, and the incapacities of public institutions as a single narrative problem. By comparison, the centre of Sahasrashirsha moves from one voice towards many. Polyphony in social experience, memories of caste and occupation, folk songs, and local political life come to the foreground. The first novel's critical axis appears to be the experienced sequence of catastrophe; the second's, the coexistence of dissenting voices. To call both merely "the memory of Mithila" would obscure their differences.

Panch Pratishat Anhar (Five Per Cent Darkness) connects financial transactions and the international structures of economic crime with the local social body of Mithila. The editorial work identifies the shop owned by Rani, Amresh's debt, unidentified payments, gambling, and institutional investigation as guiding episodes. Notably, the editor does not merely enumerate achievements: he identifies as limitations the nearly uniform disciplined speech of several characters, a slackening of dramatic movement caused by an extended chapter structure, and an excessive density of legal and administrative vocabulary. Such adverse judgements increase the credibility of criticism.

Comparison with Navya Nyaya and the Offshore Gambling Network and Anuvadak (The Translator) opens an internal triangle of money flows, instruments of proof, and linguistic mediation. The first concerns the economic connections of crime, the second the examination of evidence in jurisprudence, and the third the professional and ethical responsibilities of language. Yet if all three are reduced to exemplifications of one idea, the characters' private fears and desires and the visual power of their environments may be suppressed. Successful criticism must give equal place to the methods of argument and the aesthetic independence of fiction.

Water, Registers, Witnesses, and Names: From Symbols to Narrative Evidence

In Jal-Panji (The Water Register), the contrast between jal, "water," and panji, "register," is present in the title itself: one is mobile, the other an institution of fixing and recording. This opposition raises a question between Mithila's geography and its social archives. When something has been swept away, who will preserve its name? Which guardian of memory—a family, village, river, document, or story—will have the primary authority over truth? The editorial discussion offers a meaningful interpretation of this metaphor. Yet its literary force can be properly established only through specific scenes, characters' decisions, and evidence from the sequence of events.

In the reading of Bijji: Gohi Sabhak Beech, the contrast between a small creature and a terrifying environment becomes an emblem of unequal power. The interpretation of Satam Sakshi (The Seventh Witness) identifies a tension between external testimony and conscience. The title Patak Bhitar Likhal Nam (A Name Written Inside a Leaf) suggests identity, transience, and the fragility of writing. There is no reason to deny the usefulness of these interpretations, but the potential meaning of a title must be distinguished from the narrative truth established by the text. The extended editorial section contains an important statement of self-restraint: "A plot cannot be invented from a title until its relationship with the actual events of the story is established." This sentence deserves to be treated as a methodological legacy of the entire project.

The joint discussion of the original, adolescent, and children's versions of Gohi Sabhak Beech Jalsamadhi (A Water Burial Among the Crocodiles) raises

a further question. After a work's meanings are adapted for different readerships, how much of its original emotion, structure, and ethical conflict remains? Treating a children's edition as an inferior abridgement would be a literary mistake. Adaptation redistributes scenes, narrative risks, simplicity of language, and social complexity. A proper comparison of the three versions would require separate alignment of narrative voice, dialogue, description, and conclusions in corresponding episodes. The editorial work enters this field, but clearer examples of such comparison would strengthen its applied method.

The Expansiveness of Fiction: Collections, Sequence, and Everyday Ethics

In the editorial introductions to Parvat Upar Bhamra Je Sutal, Smritik Dosar Dis, and Ijot—Janam-Janamk Katha, poetic, memorial, and luminous meanings arise from their titles. The permanence of the "mountain" and the movement of the "bumblebee," the "other side" of memory, and a "light" extending over many lives provide gateways into the collections. Yet the overall effect of a story collection often emerges from individual endings, silences, and sequencing. Interpretation based on titles must therefore be a prelude to further textual scrutiny, not its substitute.

The great scope of Katha-Shatatrayi and Katha-Tridhara invites praise based primarily on the number of stories. The proper question for criticism, however, concerns which formal devices recur throughout them, how character types transform in relation to one another, which issues become new questions, and which stories prove comparatively weaker. The breadth of a contents list is only a preliminary indication of literary achievement. The final criteria are language, structure, necessity, and the effect upon readers.

A particularly striking tendency in close readings of the stories is the transformation of household objects into social documents. Shoes, notebooks, photographs, sweet boxes, slippers, receipts, and small mistakes become ways of raising questions of dignity, labour, shame, care, and rights. The significance of an extensive fictional undertaking lies not only in epic breadth but also in the invisible history of everyday life. Examining two or three decisive objects, their contexts, and the changing perspectives of the characters reveals the social depth of short fiction.

The fictional field also has a possible limitation. If story structures repeatedly depend upon misunderstanding, a minor discovery, the securing of evidence, the correction of paperwork, and a final reversal, repetition may turn into a familiar moral formula. Readers begin to anticipate the resolution. Greater space for insoluble social conflicts, ambiguous inner desire, divergent linguistic voices, and undecided endings could deepen the genre. The editorial work signals this danger in discussions of certain representative stories; a broader application of the insight could become one of its substantial achievements.

Fiction for Children and Adolescents: The Reader's Independent Agency

Discussion of Nav Pankhi and thirty-seven children's novels points towards the filling of a significant gap in Maithili literary history: regarding the child as a creator of knowledge and a decision-maker in the mother tongue. It challenges the tradition of treating children's literature as merely a lesson in proper conduct or a light appendix of entertainment. What questions does the child ask, what risks does the narrative assign to that child, how much space does adult authority grant the child's decisions, and how do the heroes and heroines of folk narratives reach a new generation? These are literary questions.

The essay "A Critical Method for Maithili Children's Novels," published in Videha, brings Indian ideas of rasa, aucitya, and dhvani into relation with narrative form, childhood fear, and the child's agency in a combined consideration of thirty-seven works. This context enlarges the editorial book's briefer account of children's literature. The return of narratives involving the caste background of folk heroes and historically neglected communities connects children's literature to questions of social representation. Even so, the actual responses of child readers, the accessibility of vocabulary, the harmony of illustrations and narrative content, and the comprehension of different age groups require separate testing.

In criticism of children's literature, "giving instruction" and "opening opportunities for judgement" are different activities. The finest stories do not hand the child a declared answer; they allow a young reader to observe the consequences of characters' actions, give language to fear, and recognise alternatives. From this viewpoint, the present expansion of Maithili children's novels is an important possibility, but their ultimate value must be determined by the child's literary experience, not by the number of works.

Dramatic Structure and the Inner Voice of the Ghazal: Text, Speech, and Performance

If Rang-Sangam is treated as dialogue-heavy prose alone, its theatrical character disappears. The meaning of drama accumulates through stage time, entrances and exits, pauses, practicalities of scene change, language that actors can pronounce, and the audience's collective experience. The editorial work directs attention beyond the subject of the plays towards their potential for performance; this is an appropriate direction. It should be accompanied by closer examination of the conflicts in individual plays, autonomous male and female voices, the social targets of humour, and the relationship between folk theatre and the modern stage.

It would be risky to assume a direct, uninterrupted lineage in Maithili theatre from Jyotirishwar's Dhurtasamagama through the theatrical traditions of Mithila to the modern stage. Texts, performance practices, audiences, and institutions have changed across periods. Nevertheless,

humour, satire, multilingual speech, social deception, and stage presence provide fruitful bases for comparison. Rang-Sangam's relevance to this historical line will become clear only when the relationships between the scenes of particular plays and historical material are demonstrated with evidence.

An assessment of ‘Diwan-e-Videha’, ‘Akulait Sur’, and ‘Swapname Mijjhar Hoit’ cannot rest on a uniform celebration of feeling. The ghazal calls for scrutiny of metre (*bahr*), refrain (*radif*), rhyme (*qafiya*), recurring tonal patterns, the independence of each couplet, and the overarching emotional trajectory. Song demands an orally sustainable rhythm, while free verse requires attention to the breath of the line, pauses, and the relation between images. A ghazal may address a pressing social issue yet fail to sustain its metrical obligations; it is the critic's responsibility to distinguish thematic importance from formal accomplishment. Equally, formal experiment in poetry should not be reduced to emotionalism or the advocacy of an idea.

Extended discussions of poetry and drama must also distinguish translated works from original compositions. Even when the propositional content remains similar across two languages, pronunciation, humour, propriety, and public resonance may change. The editorial collection's generic breadth makes such comparisons possible. A more fully developed criticism must, however, offer concrete evidence of differences in verbal structure and circumstances of performance.

A Theory of Criticism: The Claim to Self-Knowledge and the Responsibility of Self-Examination

One proposition in the editorials declares: ‘Criticism is literature's self-knowledge.’ A related statement maintains: ‘Modern academic criticism does not merely deliver value judgements; it develops methods of reading.’ Together these propositions elucidate the book's critical theory. If criticism is self-knowledge, the author's intentions, the editor's commitments, and the authority of literary institutions must themselves enter the field of questioning. If the method of reading is fundamental, the failures and exceptions of that method must also be demonstrated.

The essays, studies of individual writers, the prolonged undertaking of Videha, periodical indexes, and the ‘Nit Naval’ series together constitute a public culture of criticism. Alongside the appraisal of particular works, they conserve a community of readers, histories of publication, exchanges within journals, and literary archives. This situation raises a substantial question for Maithili: why does an independent literary institution matter? It matters not simply because it publishes books, but because providing spaces for divergent readings, dissent, and remembrance is also an element of literary self-determination.

Such institutional achievement nevertheless requires the independence of the critic. When author, publisher, editor, reviewer, and archivist are interconnected within the same literary circle, criticism can unintentionally

become an echo of approval. This is not an accusation; it is a methodological caution arising from the structure of an institution. Accordingly, an account that also acknowledges limitations, disagreements, historical controversies, and alternative readings increases the credibility of criticism.

The series entitled 'Nit Naval' can be read, in particular, as an emerging mode of assessment in which the work of particular authors, its contexts, and fresh interpretations remain continually open to reconsideration. The name insists on perpetual renewal. A critical question follows: does that novelty reside in the works selected, in the method of reading, or in bringing the neglected materials of literary history into view? Distinguishing these three possibilities would clarify the achievement of the series.

The Discernment of Evidence, Navya-Nyaya, and the Ethics of Narrative

Evidence recurs throughout the collection: testimony concerning crime, names in genealogical registers, historical sources, accurate meanings in translation, grammatical forms, and judicial documents. This recurrence may be regarded as an intellectual centre of the author's concerns. The analytic tradition of Navya-Nyaya supplies an intellectual background to it. Yet evidence in modern law, a historical document, and 'evidence' as a literary symbol are not of the same kind. A fictional narrator can be reliable or unreliable; a historian's evidence must be open to verification; and a court's judgement depends on its procedures.

The most important discipline of criticism is to distinguish example, inference, doubt, and the limits of judgement. The discussion of 'Five Percent Darkness' offers instances of ethical restraint in narration: Rani's signature should not be treated as infallible proof of independent consent; Trisha should protect the confidentiality of a source; and an offender's identity must not be inferred from a coincidental clue. In the novel, such procedural alertness also becomes an aesthetic device, replacing immediate resolution with the tension of uncertainty.

The limits of this approach likewise require scrutiny. If evidentiary caution makes the language of different characters excessively uniform, fiction may become a collection of illustrations of ideas. The living contradictions of character, unethical desires, inconsistent reactions, and unforeseen feelings are also constituents of literary truth. Distinguishing the use of evidence within a story from the imposition of evidentiary discipline upon the story enables a more accurate understanding of the novelistic character of the collection.

The Archives and Genealogical Registers of Mithila: A Sociology of Memory

The editorial importance of the genealogical-register project lies in its refusal to treat genealogy as a lifeless enumeration of names. Instead, it

regards such registers as long-duration records of social relations. Lineage, *gotra*, village, proximity through marriage, migration, women's family lines, and inherited titles all bear traces of social practice. But no genealogical list constitutes the history of a complete society by itself. Whose names were entered? Who remained absent? Were women recorded only through their relationships with others? How were caste, labour, and household arrangements outside the registered lineages documented? Questions such as these make the reading of genealogies an exercise in social history.

The editorial discussion of the registers contains a particularly important observation: 'What a document does not say is as important as what it says.' Instead of filling gaps with invented information, it asks after their historical causes. Silence in the historical record may indicate an absence of information, exclusion, the loss of documents, or the limitations of a system of recording. Interpretations of silence are therefore not interchangeable; the different possibilities have to be identified separately.

A continuity of methodological discernment can be observed between Videha's research essays on genealogical records and the six-volume expansion of the subject within the collected works. If such registers are regarded merely as the glorious remains of an older social classification, complex sociological questions disappear. Conversely, it would be equally misleading to treat every recorded name as uniform evidence of modern egalitarian rights. The study of social documents must attend to historical change, regional differences, relations of class and caste power, and alternative memories preserved in everyday life.

A Parallel Literary History: The Possibility of Shifting the Centre

Literary histories have often centred upon canonical authors, classical works, and urban institutions of prestige. The 'parallel' impulse associated with Videha challenges the assumption about whose writings constitute literary history and whose experiences are left at its margins. The effort in the editorials on Gajendra Thakur's collected works to place folklore, children's literature, genealogies, nonstandard linguistic forms, translation, and modern legal and economic questions within one intellectual field offers a concrete indication of this historical sensibility.

Jyotirishwar's 'Varnaratnakara' and 'Dhurta Samagama', Vidyapati's lyric corpus and medieval poetry, folk theatre, Mithila's genealogical traditions, modern stories and novels, social satire, and periodical culture are distinct bodies of material for the history of Maithili literature. Where conventional accounts accord privileged standing to poetic excellence and religious-cultural memory, a modern parallel reading proposes to bring the experience of labour, women, excluded communities, administrative records, vernacular speech, and digital media into the same historical framework. This expansion makes a parallel method necessary. But expansion cannot mean merely compiling another list; it must also examine the reasoning that organised the earlier history.

To turn 'parallel' into the slogan 'everything old is wrong and everything new is right' would contradict the method itself. Canonical texts may contain plural voices, just as marginal materials may reproduce forms of social exclusion. A credible parallel history must therefore be comparative, evidence-based, and self-critical. The editorial account of Gajendra Thakur's historiographical project announces this possibility. Establishing its detailed justification, however, requires further comparative research into chronology, documentary sources, textual variants, and the interpretations of other literary historians.

Comparison of Mayanand Mishra's historical fiction and the tradition of Harimohan Jha's social satire, together with the variety of modern Maithili storytelling, against 'Sahasrabadhani' or 'Five Percent Darkness' suggests a transformation: rural life does not lose its importance as a centre; instead, its relations with the state, floods, migration, finance, and contemporary institutions of evidence become more complex. Such comparison must nevertheless avoid claiming identical techniques merely because the works share subject matter. Differences of historical period, narrator, readership, and literary language must be made explicit.

Linguistics, Thesauri, and the Question of Standardisation

To exclude grammar and lexicography from creative literature would leave the intellectual history of a language incomplete. Projects such as 'A Parallel Grammar, Composition and Linguistics of Maithili', the 'Maithili–English Thesaurus', and the 'English–Maithili Thesaurus' regard language as an instrument of thought and inquiry. In modern Maithili, the tensions among standardised Devanagari writing, dialectal diversity, fine distinctions of meaning, and context-sensitive lexical choice become subjects of critical investigation.

The comparative relationship among Thethi, Angika, and Bajjika, in particular, cannot be settled by word lists alone. Sound systems, morphology, syntax, historical development, the self-identification of speech communities, and administrative classifications must be treated as distinct kinds of evidence. In literary criticism it is neither appropriate nor linguistically adequate to pronounce any one form inherently 'incorrect'. A dictionary becomes a living literary resource when it preserves contexts of usage, accepted variants, social registers, and the range of meanings.

A criticism of thesauri cannot be completed by counting entries. Synonymy does not establish the interchangeability of words in every context: one word may fit ordinary conversation, another legal discourse, a third folk song, and a fourth satire. The decisive criteria for lexical resources are therefore semantic sensitivity, the reliability of examples, linguistic diversity, and sustained revision. The editorials connect utility with evidence in this field, although the need for detailed, entry-based critical examination remains.

The Two-Way Movement of Translation: The Mother Tongue as Receiver and Giver

The collected works include both translations into Maithili from other languages and translations from Maithili into English. This bidirectional movement has particular significance for literary history. Maithili renderings of Sanskrit philosophy, drama, farce, and prose make classical materials accessible in a living mother tongue, while English translations of Maithili stories, novels, and poetry carry the Maithili world to a wider readership. This movement in both directions weakens the rigid opposition between 'tradition' and 'modernity'.

The editorial references to 'Bhamati', 'Atmatattvaviveka', 'Nyayakusumanjali', and 'Tattvachintamani' should not be understood as describing one homogeneous kind of translation. Philosophical terminology, relations of logical argument, and the syntax of commentaries on aphorisms demand specialised examination. In another direction, translations of 'Abhijnanashakuntalam', 'Mrichchhakatikam', 'Mudrarakshasam', 'Bhagavadajjukam', and farcical literature raise questions of dramatic conventions, social satire, performability, and shifts between linguistic registers. No single method can adequately assess all these translations.

In the context of translations from Maithili into English, the editorials observe: 'From the perspective of world literature, such translations make Maithili not merely a receiving language but also a giving language.' The historical importance of this formulation is considerable. Maithili is envisaged not solely as a cultural space that receives the literature of other languages, but as a source of its own communal experiences, metaphors, memories of rivers, and modern civic questions. Nevertheless, the availability of translations in print demonstrates access to the domain of 'world literature', not necessarily acceptance by a worldwide readership. Evaluating the actual effects of linguistic transfer requires examination of textual organisation, the meanings of metaphors, the naturalness of translated dialogue, and responses from the intended audience.

The novel 'Anuvadak' ('The Translator') becomes a self-reflection of this entire enterprise. Translation is not merely a professional service here; it is central to the ethical choices of the narrative. A mistaken interpretation of a sentence may change financial or legal consequences, while silence can itself be a decision. In this way, translation is established simultaneously as a creative, social, and epistemological activity.

The Editorial Style: Achievement, Repetition, and Uneven Judgement

The chief strength of the style of 'Editorials on the Collected Works of Gajendra Thakur' is its capacity for extensive classification. The editorial argument commonly advances from title to thesis, social purpose, comparative observation, and conclusion. Amid abundant materials, this sequence provides

readers with a sense of direction. Discussion does not disintegrate as it moves from intricate novelistic situations to lexicography and genealogical registers, because the questions of archives, evidence, language, and memory recur in new forms.

This design also has an adverse side. If almost every work is interpreted through formulas such as ‘the title contains a symbol of …’, ‘the importance of this work lies in …’, or ‘from the perspective of modern criticism …’, its particular stylistic eccentricities begin to disappear. The convenience of a critical idiom may then create an unnecessary uniformity of judgement. The remedy is close interpretation of selected scenes or passages, a willingness to reach divergent conclusions, and attention to concrete literary operations rather than general labels.

In reviews of short-story collections, translations, and poetry, some methodological formulations recur; elsewhere, the discussion becomes especially alive through its engagement with particular characters and social situations. Such unevenness should not be obscured when assessing the editorials on their own terms. It does not diminish the significance of the overall project, but identifies a practical direction for its further refinement.

Quantity is not intrinsically equivalent to critical depth. A two-line judgement on a story matters when it discloses the story's decisive implications; twenty pages of discussion are valuable only when free of needless repetition. The dignity of a collected work is determined not by its bulk but by the discernment of its critical selections and the trustworthy paths of evidence it opens for readers.

Women, Caste, Labour, and Representation: Internal Tests of a Parallel Perspective

The most demanding test of parallel history, when reading the collection's discussions of folklore, genealogies, children's narratives, domestic fiction, and modern institutions, is social representation. Does a woman's name appear in a genealogical register solely as somebody's daughter or wife, or is the possibility of an independent life history preserved? Are working communities simply placed upon a pedestal as heroic figures of folk culture, or are their ordinary economic struggles, education, and political inequalities made visible? Do girls and adolescent women possess genuine agency in the stories, or are their decisions finally absorbed into the instruction of adults? These questions reach beyond individual works to test the editorial perspective itself.

Folk memory need not always be emancipatory; it can also transmit exclusion, caste hierarchy, and gender inequality. Accordingly, placing folk traditions on an equal footing with classical knowledge should mean critical parity, not an unexamined elevation of every inherited folk convention. A discerning parallel history must consider both the social usefulness and the limitations of genealogies and folk narratives.

Research debates published in Videha on feminist and Dalit approaches to literary criticism pose questions internal to this editorial enterprise. Whom does literary expansion bring into its community of readers, and whom does it leave in silence? The answers to questions opened within a book are not furnished by fixed declarations; they require repeated testing through particular texts.

Videha and the Literary Public Sphere: From Periodical to Research Archive

Videha occupies an important historical position in this collection because the periodical serves not only as a vehicle of circulation but also as a repository of critical writing. Its successive issues, research articles, editorials, translations, children's literature, genealogical studies, linguistic work, and studies of particular authors give a long-term memory to literary public debate. A comprehensive reading of an author's work thereby becomes, in effect, a method of entering into dialogue with this public institution.

The periodical and the book have historically distinct functions. A journal preserves disputes as they unfold; a book gives selected materials order, relative stability, and comparative relations. The presence of Videha's research index and book collection reveals a conjunction of these two forms. When criticism rooted in print culture engages a digital archive, accessibility grows, but so do responsibilities concerning the durability of sources, differences between editions, authorial attribution, and the identification of revised material.

One achievement of this book is to provide a framework for future research topics in Maithili criticism. A subsequent scholar may select, from a single volume, the literary development of a particular author, a distinct cluster of stories, the social history of genealogies, or questions concerning the vocabulary of translation. For such uses, however, distinctions between the original work, the critic's commentary, and a periodical's editorial information must remain clear.

An Integrated Reassessment of the Central Arguments

The collection's first achievement is to remove artificial partitions between genres and construct a shared intellectual field. By identifying connections among prose, verse, classical learning, history, children's literature, grammar, and translation, it discloses the local linguistic foundations of knowledge. Its second achievement is sensitivity to evidence: refusing to turn every silence into a fact, every coincidence into a verdict, or every title into a plot. Its third is the social aspiration of a parallel literary history in which folk knowledge, neglected archives, and modern civic experience enter into debate with older institutions of authority.

Three main points invite critical scrutiny. First, different literary genres do not share identical criteria of assessment; general theoretical terms must therefore be supplemented by close examination of the specific metre, scene,

event, source, or technique of each work. Second, comprehensiveness must be distinguished from original evidence: an editorial description does not, by itself, prove the aesthetic excellence of every text described. Third, within a vast sequence, unnecessary repetition and generalised judgements may reduce the sharpness of a reader's experience.

Nevertheless, the book raises a decisive question: how can a multiplicity of modern forms of knowledge be created in the mother tongue? The answer offered is not a story of uninterrupted progress, but a combined process of creativity, translation, memory, social responsibility, and discipline in the use of sources. For this reason the book deserves not only praise but exacting criticism. Its ability to sustain serious critical engagement is itself a major literary accomplishment.

Conclusion

Ashish Anchinhar's 'Editorials on the Collected Works of Gajendra Thakur' constitutes a notable effort to transform the breadth of an author's creative output into an extensive architecture of editorial reading in Maithili. At its centre are the language of evidence, the geography of water, the memory preserved in genealogies, the dialogue between folk knowledge and classical learning, judicial discernment, children's imaginative rights, and the bidirectional cultural journey of translation. The book's most important insistence is that classical and modern questions of knowledge can be asked in the mother tongue, and that Maithili itself is capable of becoming an adequate language of intellectual inquiry.

Its critical achievement is most luminous when the editor acknowledges a work's limitations, maintains distinctions between imagination and evidence, and captures the singular voice of a particular text. Where generalised models, formulaic approval, or conjectures based upon titles take precedence, the same method of self-examination should be applied again. The expansive social commitment generated by a parallel literary history will endure only if the evidence of established and newer traditions alike remains equally open to questioning.

Ultimately, the point of the volume is not to determine the total greatness of a single author, but to open the full possibilities of Maithili criticism to dispute, evidence, disagreement, and rereading. Literary history is not merely an accumulation of archival records; it is an enduring public conversation conducted through criticism. Reading 'Editorials on the Collected Works of Gajendra Thakur' with due attention to its range, methodological promise, and remediable limitations will reveal its proper place in that conversation.

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REVIEW 5

Priti Karan Setu Banhal

Bridges, Memory, and the Digital Public Sphere

Primary Work Reviewed: ‘Priti Karan Setu Banhal—Redefining Maithili’, edited by Ashish Anchinhar (2024).

Abstract

‘Priti Karan Setu Banhal—Redefining Maithili’ (2024), edited by Ashish Anchinhar, is a distinctive collective venture in contemporary Maithili critical literature. Its basic arrangement consists of three parts associated with Kripanand Thakur, Preeti Thakur, and Gajendra Thakur, but its thematic reach extends beyond family biography to comics, children's literature, oral tradition, digital journalism, genealogical research, scripts, dictionaries, publishing culture, novels, criticism, and alternative literary institutions. The present study reads the volume not merely as a collection of celebratory writing but as an active editorial structure for constructing literary reputation and cultural memory. On one hand, Preeti Thakur's comics seek to bring Mithila's diverse folk heroes to children through a visual language; on the other, the material associated with Gajendra Thakur reveals emerging possibilities for a digital Maithili public sphere and new resources of knowledge. The study also demonstrates that claims to priority, the social limitations of genealogical registers, personality-centred praise, and inconsistencies in editorial selection demand independent scrutiny. The volume's significance lies in this duality: it both supplies material for history and becomes an instrument of historical construction.

Keywords

Maithili literary history; Ashish Anchinhar; Preeti Thakur; Gajendra Thakur; comics; children's literature; Videha; genealogical registers; digital public sphere; parallel literary tradition; editorial criticism.

The Character of the Book and the Central Critical Question

‘Priti Karan Setu Banhal’ was published in 2024. Its publication details describe it as a critical appreciation of the work of Gajendra Thakur and Preeti Thakur. Its title is drawn from Mithila's folk-song tradition, while the English subtitle, ‘Redefining Maithili’, announces a contemporary aspiration. There is a productive tension between these indications: cultural continuity carried by the folk voice on one side, and an attempt to redefine language and literature in relation to new media, forms, and readers on the other. The critic's first question is how the volume connects these objectives, and where that connection succeeds or remains incomplete.

The volume is not a single argument by its editor. It brings together appraisals, disagreements, reminiscences, interviews, collections of information, and bibliographies by numerous writers. It would therefore be inappropriate to regard every statement as the editor's definitive position. Some essays undertake direct textual analysis; others offer biographical recollections, assemble research information, or argue for an author's social or cultural importance. These differences are not obstacles to analysis but structural features of the book. A suitable critical method distinguishes the original 'work', the 'response to a work', and the 'editorial arrangement'.

Of the three principal parts, the first centres on memories of Kripanand Thakur's life; the second concerns Preeti Thakur's comics, Mithila's folk divinities, the early history of comics, and interview material; the third offers a broad examination of Gajendra Thakur's digital, cultural, linguistic, and literary initiatives. The sequence moves from genealogical and familial information through children's literature towards publicly accessible literary institutions. It is thematic rather than chronological, and thus asks readers to discover connections across changing subjects for themselves.

Editorial Vision: Title, Folk Song, and the Structure of the Volume

According to the editor's own account, the title comes from a line associated with a *barahmasa* folk song. The decision to use different lines of the song to identify the contents, introduction, parts on Kripanand Thakur, Preeti Thakur and Gajendra Thakur, biographical notes, and conclusion is more than ornament. It is an attempt to introduce the language of folk culture into the structure of prose criticism. The 'bridge' symbol proposes connections not simply through the creative partnership of husband and wife, but between generations, older and newer media, oral and written memory, and mainstream and parallel readerships.

The editor's introduction expressly treats editing as an intellectual act requiring judgement rather than external decoration. He writes: 'Editing is essentially a matter of perspective, vision, and critical thinking.' This statement is central to the volume's understanding of itself. Soliciting contributions, including disagreements, recovering previously published materials, accepting differences of spelling, and supplying contextual information to readers are all practical manifestations of that 'vision'. The editor acknowledges that different contributors use different forms of language, and does not favour complete uniformity. The result preserves linguistic diversity, although it may sometimes challenge ease of reading and textual coherence.

To organise a volume through a folk song is to move Maithili's oral literature beyond a fixed division between 'high' and 'low' literary forms. Yet according symbolic prestige to a folk song is not the same as studying its singing community, gendered context, occasion of performance, varying versions, and social circumstances. The volume accomplishes the first task effectively and opens possibilities for the second, without pursuing them in

every instance. Identifying this limitation does not diminish folk culture; it recognises the need for historical scrutiny of folk sources.

Kripanand Thakur: From Personal Reminiscence to Social History

Siyaram Jha ‘Saras’ contributes the principal essay of the first part, ‘Karot Pherait Gamak Nidarshak: K.N.T.’. Instead of a conventional biography arranged around dates of birth and death, it presents a village, schools, public life, cooperative social labour, and administrative and cultural surroundings. Memories of an earlier Madhubani, educational institutions, teachers, and rural theatre connect an individual's life with the public memory of an era. Here ‘personality’ is expressed not as private identity alone but through participation in a community.

The essay does not matter because it offers a definitive historical verdict on Kripanand Thakur; it matters because it makes a local source of social memory accessible. For researchers, an event, date, conversation, and felt experience narrated in memoir do not occupy identical evidentiary positions. Experience may convey literary truth, but not every recollected statement automatically becomes documentary proof. A critical reading accordingly receives this work as material for investigating changes in the rural middle class, education, cooperation, and public morality, not as a substitute for conclusive history. The first part thus introduces the question of cultural inheritance between generations that informs the volume as a whole.

Preeti Thakur's Comics: The Visual Remaking of Oral Narrative

Preeti Thakur's creative presence constitutes one of the book's most distinctive literary contributions. Professor Veena Thakur's discussion explains that of the sixteen stories in ‘Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Comics’ (2008), nine concern Gonu Jha; the others feature folk or historical figures such as Reshma-Chuharmal, Naika-Banijara, Bhagata Jyoti Punjiar, Mahua Ghatwarin, Raja Salhes, Chhechhan Maharaj, and Kalidasa. The observation ‘All the characters represent Mithila's culture’ discloses the genre's principal intention. Their selection maps a shared geography of oral legend, folk belief, wit, resourcefulness, resistance, and the memories of marginalised communities.

A comic is not merely an illustrated transcription of a folktale. Where the linear sequence of words conducts reading in one direction, the arrangement of images allows the eye to move among objects, characters, and gestures simultaneously. Unfilled space, facial expression, sequential panels, condensed dialogue, and visual memory create a new narrative rhythm. To restrict Preeti Thakur's work to ‘children's entertainment’ would therefore diminish its aesthetic accomplishment. Familiar narratives of Mithila acquire a new medium of reception when transformed into visual stories. The criticism collected in the volume recognises the change, although it devotes less sustained formal attention to panel design, chromatic sequence, point of view, and word-image relations.

Comparing the essays by Professor Veena Thakur, Dr Raman Jha, Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu', Dhirendra Kumar, and Durganand Mandal reveals that the defining characteristics of comics are not understood uniformly. Some see them as instruments of cultural preservation, others as remedies for the scarcity of children's literature, introductions to Mithila's popular and subaltern heroes, or the foundation of a new genre. Reading these positions together shows that 'preservation' and 'creation' are different but connected undertakings. When orally transmitted stories acquire a visual form, their inherited content is not merely retained unchanged; it is also reorganised in relation to the sensibilities and curiosity of a new generation.

'Maithili Comics' (2009) includes subjects such as Raja Salhes, Dina-Bhadri, Naika-Banijara, Bodhi Kayastha, and the final years of Vidyapati's life. The selection is not simply a hierarchy of fame. The traditions of Dina-Bhadri, associated with the Musahar community, and of Salhes have particular caste and social foundations. Comics offer an opportunity to connect these memories to a larger readership of children. Yet it would be premature, without comparing the original oral traditions with their visual adaptations, to conclude that every depiction does full justice to the perspectives of the communities represented. The opportunity for representation and the adequacy of representation are separate questions.

Children's Literature, Women's Writing, and Language Acquisition

Dr Shefalika Verma's essay questions the tendency to place women's writing at the margins of literary history. This context protects Preeti Thakur's work from being reduced to an appendix to the work of her writer-husband. The volume itself attends to the distinction: Preeti Thakur has her own independent choices and accomplishments in comics, illustration, translation, and writing for children. Sociologically, this matters because the presence of women writers is becoming visible not only in poetry or the expected domains of domestic writing, but also in visual technology and the spread of language.

Preeti Thakur's interview supplies an autobiographical basis for the discussion. Asked when she began making pictures, she replies: 'I used to draw from childhood; when my son was born in 2000 and began to speak, the thought came to me.' This brief answer makes domestic experience a source of creativity without confining the work to the home. Children's reading interests, the need for pictures, the coexistence of books and electronic media, and the question of accessible language all emerge in the interview. Such direct testimony from a creator is valuable, although autobiographical accounts must still be distinguished from critical interpretation.

The relation between the mother tongue and children's literature is decisive here. A language does not remain alive solely through a school curriculum or constitutional recognition. Through household conversation, play, storytelling, visual art, and pleasurable reading, a child comes to inhabit it as a linguistic world. Comics can be effective at precisely this threshold, where oral stories and alphabetic reading meet. Yet the assertion that any individual book

has resolved a crisis of language transmission would exceed the evidence. A sustained response must involve regular publishing, libraries, schools, distribution, and research into readers.

Testing Claims to 'Being First' in Literary History

The introduction and materials on the early history of comics present Preeti Thakur as the first Maithili woman comics writer. The gathered records identify a sequence: translations 'Chhot a Paigh' (2002) and 'Mal-Jal a Janwar Dis Dekhu' (2003); the original publication 'Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Comics' (2008); 'Maithili Comics' (2009); 'Folk Divinities of Mithila' (2010); and 'Vidyapati's Purush Pariksha' (2012). Their historical value lies partly in allowing a distinction between 'the first comic' and 'the first original comic'. The history of translation must not be erased from the history of original composition.

However, claims to absolute priority depend upon a clear definition of the genre. A single-panel cartoon, a newspaper caricature, a serial picture strip, a translated comic, an original comic, and an extended graphic narrative do not constitute one undifferentiated category. Ashish Anchinhar's historical essay investigates earlier achievements and remains open to revision when new evidence appears. Within the collection, Dhirendra Kumar's remarks also offer a different indication concerning preceding comics. Rather than suppressing this alternative voice as an inconsistency, it should be recognised as a productive challenge to historical scholarship. Preeti Thakur's achievement is important on the evidence presented, but no categorical conclusion for all time is secure without a systematic examination of earlier periodical materials.

Videha's book catalogue, which separately classifies original and translated works, provides a useful tool for such examination. More than a listing of available books, it can enable the history of a genre to distinguish the type of work, language, medium, and sequence of revised editions. The question raised by this volume will be most fruitful for future literary history if the study of comics becomes not merely a dispute over publication dates but a history of aesthetics, readership, visual language, and social representation.

Digital Journalism and the Literary Public Sphere

The third part, devoted to Gajendra Thakur, begins with digital libraries and journalism. Kalpana Jha's essay demonstrates the usefulness of free book resources through the experience of accessible reading. Kirtinath Jha considers two historical obstacles to publication—finance and editorial approval—and sees alternative points of entry in digital media. Lal Dev Kamat's essay traces technological and communicative changes of medium. Read alongside the editor's introduction, these perspectives show that web journalism here concerns not merely news dissemination but the redistribution of literary opportunity.

Several contributors discuss the beginnings of a web presence and stages in the development of ‘Bhalsarik Gachh’, ‘Samadiya’, and ‘Videha’. It is prudent to read their dates as claims supported by particular sources rather than as a single settled chronology. Starting a blog, naming an electronic journal, establishing regular fortnightly publication, and institutionalising a publishing structure are different events. References to Videha's fortnightly publication beginning in 2008 are important in these assessments; to produce its complete chronology, however, the original issues, editorial notices, and extant archives must be collated.

Democratisation of publication inevitably raises difficult questions. The presence of a book in a digital collection is not the same as its effective accessibility to rural students, economically disadvantaged readers, or people with limited devices. Free access lowers one barrier, but equipment, connectivity, searchability, script support, accommodations for visual disability, long-term preservation, and the critical quality of content also determine access. The principal achievement of the collected material is to establish the necessity of digital media; its next critical stage should assemble social evidence about access and investigate how people actually read.

From ‘Mithila Mihir’ to ‘Videha’: Continuity and Rupture

Lakshman Jha ‘Sagar’, in ‘Mithila Mihir and the Videha Web Journal’, creates an opportunity to compare the cultural role of a traditional periodical with the achievement of a digital fortnightly. The historical standing of ‘Mithila Mihir’ rested upon its cultivation of a shared site for publication, editorial selection, and literary discussion in Maithili. In the case of ‘Videha’, the medium changes: the internet replaces physical distribution, reproducible materials replace restricted print runs, and an alternative community of writers challenges the centralised point of entry. Yet the basic questions of a literary journal—whose writing is admitted, according to what criteria, and how it is received—remain alive in both periods.

Such a comparison should not collapse into the binary judgement ‘the old was superior’ versus ‘the new is more democratic’. The institutional memory of older journals and the immediacy of digital access are different strengths. Their editorial economies, linguistic standards, reach among readers, spaces for dissent, and capacities for preservation offer comparative terms for literary history. The volume initiates this comparison but does not present systematic longitudinal data on circulation, regular readership, editorial policies, and participation. This is both its use and its limitation.

Genealogical Registers: Heritage, Lineage, and the Politics of the Archive

Essays on genealogical registers by Vinayanand Jha, Jagdishchandra Thakur ‘Anil’, Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra, and Bhavnath Jha constitute an important thematic cluster. Such registers are not merely instruments for understanding marriage rules relating to lineage and *gotra*: they also record villages of

origin, clans, individuals, chronology, social relationships, and historical displacement. Publishing and digitising these sources can open old manuscript materials to researchers and curious general readers alike. The volume attributes the work of 'genome mapping' and the editing of registers jointly to Gajendra Thakur, Nagendra Kumar Jha, and the genealogist Vidyanand Jha. Amid accounts of individual accomplishment, this dimension of cooperation should not be forgotten.

Recognising the historical usefulness of genealogies does not eliminate the question of social selection. Communities excluded from records of particular names, ranks, and marriage practices will be less visible in them. The silence of a source can itself become a social fact. Research must therefore ask which communities were documented and for what social purposes, how original entries are distinguished from later copies, and how evidence obtained from genealogies can be compared with other historical materials. Severing the work of 'preservation' from social justice risks making the historical source merely an instrument of lineage prestige.

Within the volume, Bhavnath Jha raises practical concerns about presentation, the organisation of headings, and accessibility to readers. The historical importance of these criticisms should not be underestimated. Sheer quantities of material do not automatically create usefulness. Research requires control over textual variants, indexes of names, source identification, an explicit transliteration policy, and facilities for checking readings. Thus the combined argument of these essays goes beyond commendation: developing methods for scholarly use of the archived materials is as necessary as making those materials available.

Language, Script, and Dictionaries: The Literary Importance of Foundational Work

Uday Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa' situates Maithili–English, English–Maithili, and computational-terminology projects within a wide history of lexicography. Literary histories usually foreground poetry, fiction, and drama, but literary production across genres has a precarious foundation without dictionaries, writing technologies, spelling standards, and accessible semantic information. It may be tempting to divide lexicographical labour from creative work. Yet decisions about a word's semantic field, evidence of usage, historical variants, dialectal diversity, and technical neologisms shape the intellectual future of a language community.

Discussion of publishing materials in multiple scripts, including Tirhuta, demonstrates that script is not merely a question of pride in historical inheritance but also of practical reading rights. Making the same language accessible in different scripts can reduce the distance between heritage and contemporary access. Sustainable multiscript publication nevertheless requires standardised character encoding, search facilities, checks for translation and transliteration errors, and training for new readers. Work on dictionaries and

scripts should therefore be placed not at the margins of literary history but within the structural history of literary communication.

‘Kurukshetram Antarmanak’: Generic Intermixture and Intellectual Expansion

In the collection, Uday Narayan Singh ‘Nachiketa’ discusses seven divisions of ‘Kurukshetram Antarmanak’, covering treatises, essays and criticism, novels, poetry, stories, drama, epic, and literature for children and adolescents. The list does more than affirm an author's productivity; it suggests an aspiration towards a many-sided creative programme in contemporary Maithili. Where critical study, narrative, drama, and experiments in language for children coexist within one creative world, generic boundaries cannot remain fixed.

However, versatility does not automatically entail artistic success. A work intellectually expansive in conception may be less concentrated in its plot; linguistic daring may increase demands upon readers. The presence of multiple critics addressing ‘Kurukshetram Antarmanak’ makes divergent evaluations possible. Rajdev Mandal's epistolary response, Shiv Kumar Jha ‘Tillu”s readerly assessment, and Ashok's study of the novel offer different forms of critical expression. Rather than subsuming these approaches under one conclusion, they should be allowed to test one another.

‘Sahasrabadhani’: A Narrative of Social Change Within the Family

Arvind Thakur's ‘Sahasrabadhani: In My View (Some Observations)’ can be counted among the more closely text-based studies in this collection. His opening proposition is: ‘“Sahasrabadhani” is essentially the story of the successive evolution of four generations of one family.’ A multigenerational family narrative renders social change not as an abstract political declaration but through concrete forms of education, professions, opportunities, humiliation, decisions, and family tensions. Examining relationships between characters and generations, the critic begins to interpret new education, structures succeeding colonial rule, and modern professional institutions.

From this perspective, the study of ‘Sahasrabadhani’ can also become an examination of the internal fragmentation of a family history. What one generation calls progress, the next recognises as limited. Tensions between public power and private ambition form the narrative's ethical terrain. The criticism available here is valuable because it concentrates less on laudatory adjectives than on the relationship between narrative structure and social change. Nevertheless, a critical account quoted within the collection cannot be treated as the final standard for the novel without independent attention to its entire text.

Social Inequality, Narrative Form, and the Parallel Tradition

Abha Jha's 'Stories That Penetrate the Layers of Social Inequality' identifies caste divisions, women's experiences, hunger, migration, the commercialisation of education, ecology, and structures of power within Gajendra Thakur's fiction. The essay is especially valuable because it insists on reading literature through the complexity of social experience rather than through generic prestige or linguistic skill alone. Yet a story's ethical significance cannot be established simply by listing its subjects. Point of view, contradictions within characters, the narrator's distance, and the final artistic effect are also decisive. Social realism should be evaluated with these distinctions in mind.

Acharya Ramanand Mandal's essay explicitly raises the question of relations between the mainstream and parallel currents of Maithili literature. Here literary history is not just a succession of celebrated authors, but a history of the institutions that confer prestige. Who entered the curriculum? Whose works were reprinted? Who received prizes or opportunities for review? Which dialects and social classes were accepted as the substance of 'standard literature'? Such questions must occupy the centre of critical historiography. Nonetheless, treating the mainstream and its alternatives as two impermeable camps could conceal their internal disagreements, inequalities, and mutual influences. The volume raises this complex problem, and its strongest reading leaves the inquiry open.

The Place of Dissent: Internal Criticism in a Celebratory Collection

A familiar risk in books devoted to individual personalities is that critical disagreement becomes submerged in honorific language. Dhanakar Thakur's essay 'Videha and Gajendra' resists this danger. Its opening declaration —'Gajendra Thakur is not Videha, nor was or is Videha Gajendra'—insists upon a distinction between an individual and an institution. Dhanakar Thakur objects to aspects of editorial decision-making, the awards system, presentation, and organisational structure. Such objections are not necessarily universally accepted conclusions, but their presence widens the collection's critical horizon.

The initiating editor undoubtedly plays an important role in sustaining an institution. Yet its history also includes readers, writers, technical collaborators, associate editors, printers, and the social support that enables its work. Many essays in the volume accord considerable personal credit, while some register collective labour. Distinguishing the language of 'heroic individual achievement' from that of 'institutional history' helps illuminate this unevenness. The book's critical capacity increases when it permits disagreement; its evidentiary value diminishes when intense praise replaces argument.

Interviews and Editorial Commentary: Constructing a Living History

Alongside Preeti Thakur's interview, the collection includes earlier conversations with Gajendra Thakur and a newer interview. Such materials provide direct evidence of contemporary opinions, disagreements, and self-assessments. Placing earlier and later accounts together makes it possible to examine changes and continuities in claims over time. This is an important contribution to biographical literature: beyond the author's works and their external reception, the author discusses the rationale, limitations, and programme of his own activities.

Yet an interview is also a form of self-presentation. The interviewer's interests, public controversies, and the respondent's circumstances influence the answers. Interviews are therefore best treated as records of thought at particular moments, not as entirely impartial histories. Editorial notes create dialogue among contributors, but when they merely offer a rebuttal without examining the original critic's question in full, the reader must keep these two levels of criticism distinct. Recognising the distinction protects the reader's independence in interpreting disagreement.

A Comparative Framework for Literary History

The history of Maithili literature has generally been organised as a development from early poetry, medieval courtly and devotional verse, through modern journalism, the novel, short fiction, and contemporary literary creation. ‘Priti Karan Setu Banhal’ introduces another important axis into this broad sequence: the history of the media through which literature circulates socially. If a history beginning with Vidyapati's poetic stature or the prose of ‘Varnaratnakara’ remains only a catalogue of great works, changes involving comics, children's language, libraries, manuscript preservation, script accessibility, and digital public spaces will receive insufficient attention. The collection helps make this absence visible, although it is not itself a complete literary history.

The book's opening through a folk song, the visual reanimation of folk heroes in Preeti Thakur's comics, and the public accessibility of manuscript genealogies discussed in the essays together constitute a history of ‘memory and media’ that crosses the conventional ancient–medieval–modern division. In this perspective, a literary inheritance is not a fixed body of material but a sequence of textual variants and transformations. Oral voices, printed books, newspapers, electronic journals, dictionaries, and readers' discussions change one another. This interdependence can serve as a foundation for writing the literary history of contemporary Maithili.

Comparing the journalistic tradition of ‘Mithila Mihir’ with Videha's online publication offers an opportunity to understand the social effects of changing media. Earlier, editing, postal distribution, printing, and restricted institutional entry were central; the newer period allows digitisation,

continued archiving, and extensive redistribution. But the digital age is not automatically egalitarian. Measures of popularity, editorial prejudices, unequal access to networks, and the problems of permanent preservation may reproduce old inequalities in new forms. This qualification makes the historical comparison more even-handed.

Structural Imbalance and the Responsibilities of Criticism

The title of the volume presents Preeti Thakur and Gajendra Thakur together, but their proportions within the contents are unequal. The sequence contains one extended memoir of Kripanand Thakur, ten critical, historical, or interview-related contributions on Preeti Thakur, and twenty-nine named essays and interviews on Gajendra Thakur. This imbalance is not merely arithmetic; it concerns the distribution of readers' attention. The announced restitution of a woman's literary history would have been more effective if the aesthetics of visual storytelling, the adaptation of comics, direct responses from child readers, and the study of creative labour had received fuller treatment.

A second limitation is the recurrence of celebratory vocabulary. Adjectives such as ‘historic’, ‘unprecedented’, ‘first’, and ‘vast’ register the energy of an achievement in many of the essays, but do not constitute scholarly conclusions without cross-checking their sources. The presence of different writers' opinions is natural in an edited volume; research nevertheless requires verified timelines for such claims, documentary foundations, and adequate consideration of earlier attempts. The volume supplies a great deal of material for conducting these inquiries, which remains one of its admirable qualities.

A third limitation is the uneven depth of historical treatment. Extensive material on genealogical registers is available, but the contradictions within stories of folk heroes, the aesthetics of the visual medium, the readership of periodicals, and the social use of free archives require further comparative study. These limitations should not be understood merely as deficiencies: they provide a map of potential research topics. The volume raises questions whose solutions might not have fitted within a single edited book.

Research Method, Evidence, and the Reliability of Interpretation

This study compares the original collection's editorial introduction, arrangement of parts, thematic clusters, selected reviews, interviews, and internal bibliographies. Statements about historical sequences are treated as the claims of the respective contributors. Where Videha's book catalogue permits additional confirmation of a publication year or genre, it is used as a supplementary source. This method avoids the error of treating an author's original work and a reviewer's assessment of that work as a single thing.

Historical interpretation requires distinctions among levels of reference. The availability of a published work is one sort of fact; declaring it the ‘first’ or the ‘best’ is a different sort of judgement; measuring its social effects calls

for a third kind of inquiry. Without these distinctions, literary homage may pass for history. Likewise, the presence of folk traditions in comics can be established by examining their content, but proof that such representation has eliminated social discrimination would require an entirely different body of evidence.

Conclusion: The ‘Bridge’ Reconsidered

The lasting importance of ‘Priti Karan Setu Banhal’ is that it does not confine literary work in Maithili to the narrow act of publishing creative writing. The social memory of schools and villages, visual narratives made by a woman artist, renewed readings of folk divinities and neglected heroes, the public sphere of digital journals, the historical preservation of genealogies, the construction of scripts and dictionaries, and the social criticism embodied in fiction collectively reveal a much larger structure of literary life. Literary history encompasses not only celebrated works and names but also media, collaborators, readers, editors, and conditions of access. This is the volume's especially significant insight.

Alongside these achievements, its critical limitations are clear. Further research must establish documentary support for its claims, offer more balanced consideration of female and male creators, distinguish personal prestige from the independent history of institutions, examine social exclusions in the genealogical record, and study digital access objectively. The disagreements already represented in the collection legitimise this programme. A ‘bridge’ exists in the fullest sense only where praise, questions, evidence, and dissent can meet in dialogue. By this measure, the edited volume emerges as an important source for contemporary Maithili criticism, a polyphonic cultural document, and a provocative foundation for future literary historiography.

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REVIEW 6

Setusham: Vibrant Maithili

The Bridge as Metaphor and an Inclusive Literary History

Research Abstract

Edited by Ashish Anchinhar, ‘Setusham: Vibrant Maithili’ documents the institutional transformation of modern Maithili literature alongside the creative work of Preeti Thakur and Gajendra Thakur. The collection contains two essays on Preeti Thakur's children's literature and comics, and fourteen on Gajendra Thakur's digital editing, preservation of genealogies, lexicography, multiscript publishing, emerging writers, commitment to ordinary people, criticism, and literary history. The central argument of this study is that the book's significance lies not merely in celebrating two individuals but in regarding literature as a composite phenomenon of creation, institutional structure, dissemination, archives, editorial selection, and readers' participation. The bridge metaphor derived from Vedic chant, the place of women's writing for children, the entry of caste and class into literary discussion, the possibilities of a digital library, and disengagement from the culture of public literary platforms both conflict and connect with one another. Yet uneven documentary evidence, the celebratory orientation of several contributors, comparatively limited attention to women's creative achievement, and the need to verify numerous claims to priority also reveal the volume's limitations. Reading these tensions critically, the essay proposes a multicentred view of literary history.

Keywords: Maithili literature; Ashish Anchinhar; Preeti Thakur; Gajendra Thakur; Videha; comics; digital humanities; genealogical registers; popular commitment; parallel history; editing.

The Central Critical Problem: Text, Individual, and Institution

The literary histories of modern Indian languages have commonly been constructed through chronological lists of celebrated works by poets, storytellers, novelists, and critics. The work of journal editors, those who make books available, the preservation of forgotten manuscripts, early mentoring of new writers, and the creation of a visual literary world for child readers have often remained peripheral. 'Setusham' addresses that periphery. Counting 'how many books were written' will not suffice to understand what the volume brings forward. We must ask how the books reached readers, whose language was published, whose memories were preserved, and which literary voices received recognition.

For this reason, criticism of 'Setusham' must proceed on two levels. The first consists of the contributors' respective arguments: praise, experience, historical description, dissent, and proposals for the future. The second is the collection itself as an edited literary work: its organisation, anticipated readership, title, subdivisions, Vedic allusions, relations among essays, and ideological unevenness. Keeping these levels distinct reveals what the volume establishes through direct evidence and where it depends on value judgements or personal experience. Independent criticism must preserve this difference rather than effacing it out of loyalty or disagreement.

The Architecture of the Collection and Editorial Autonomy

The collection opens with an extensive introduction by the editor, Ashish Anchinhar. A descriptive list of contributions follows, together with a brief section on Preeti Thakur's writing and a substantially larger one on the diverse work of Gajendra Thakur. Munni Kamat and Ira Mallik open a discussion of women's creativity, children as readers, and visual language. Kailash Kumar Thakur, Vikas Vatsanabh, Bhairav Lal Das, Poonam Jha 'Sudha', Shiv Kumar Prasad, Kalpana Jha, Munnaji, Dhanakar Thakur, Hitnath Jha, Praveen Kumar Jha, Kundan Karn, Jagadanand Jha 'Manu', Ujjwal Kumar Jha, and Mukesh Anand then address differing dimensions of the digital literary sphere. Their distinctive social experiences, styles, and disciplines of knowledge partly prevent the collection from becoming a uniformly laudatory testimonial.

The numerical ratio of two to fourteen contributors is not an incidental statistic; it is an editorial circumstance that affects meaning. The title and introduction claim a shared creative enterprise, but most of the discussion concentrates on Gajendra Thakur's institutional achievements and intellectual labour. Preeti Thakur's independent contributions receive relatively limited space. Readers are consequently invited to imagine a joint achievement without receiving equivalently developed accounts of both. It is

more reasonable to identify this as a structural limitation than to declare it a proven defect of editorial intention. Naming the imbalance is a first condition of recognising Preeti Thakur's independent literary position.

In the introduction, the editor explains the new collection's complementary relationship with the previously edited 'Priti Karan Setu Banhal—Redefining Maithili'. Where the first volume adopted a folk-song-based presentation, the new one links its internal parts through Vedic verses. The editor also explains why fresh essays were solicited, repeated contributions by previous authors restricted, and space offered to writers outside the mainstream. This editorial self-examination matters: the book comments on its own structure and can be understood not only as a thematic anthology but as an exposition of the theory of editing.

The Semantic Structure of Setusham: Chant, Bridge, and Public Ethics

The title 'Setusham' derives its meaning from a contemporary rereading of an ancient Vedic chant. Distinguishing the original mantra from its sung rendition, the editor identifies four symbolic means of crossing beyond anger, greed, disbelief, and falsehood. His compact interpretation reads: 'Build four bridges; cross four obstacles.' The importance of this statement lies less in a perfectly identical literal meaning than in the new critical use of a cultural allusion. The bridge of the Samaveda becomes a metaphor for literary ethics: the path of creation is made not through individual talent alone but through exchange, restraint, trustworthiness, and cooperation.

The editor goes on to identify the culture of literary stages, garlands and microphones, attachment to awards, plagiarism, and efforts to block the progress of other writers as obstacles in literary life. The mythic-religious allusion thereby enters contemporary institutional criticism. The metaphor's strength is that it offers readers an ethical vocabulary of evaluation; its limitation is that ethical ideals cannot themselves verify factual achievements. Critiques of literary prizes and the actual practices of conferring honours, for example, require investigation through different sets of historical evidence.

Discussing the relation between folk tradition and Vedic culture, the editor explicitly chooses the order 'folk–Veda'. The first volume's folk singing and the second's Vedic illumination become different expressions of one cultural connection. The history of that relationship, however, has never been uniform: the independence of folk traditions, women's song cultures, the power relations embedded in genealogical registration, and the prestige assigned to Vedic learning must all remain visible. Ignoring these tensions would reduce 'folk–Veda' to a decorative emblem. Reading it as a question makes it a measure of the volume's inclusive claims.

Preeti Thakur's Comics: An Independent Creative Sphere in Children's Literature

Munni Kamat's ‘Mrs Preeti Thakur: An Accomplished Writer for the Child's Mind’ regards children's literature as a foundation for a language's future. She emphasises accessible stories, visual attraction, and familiarity with folk culture for young readers. She discusses ‘Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Comics’, ‘Maithili Comics’, ‘Folk Divinities of Mithila’, and ‘Vidyapati's Purush Pariksha’. Through these works, folk figures distinguished by wit and intelligence, Mithila's heroic legends, folk divinities, and classical narratives re-enter the world of children. Comics thus combine language acquisition with cultural remembrance rather than serving solely as entertainment for the young.

Ira Mallik's ‘Preeti Thakur's Contribution to Maithili Comics’ extends this discussion into the study of visual art. She emphasises the interplay of line, colour, figure, traditional *kachni* and *bharni* techniques, and narrative subject. The translation of a literary story into pictures alters its sequence, atmosphere, physical expression of characters, and the reader's inferences. A young reader, in particular, makes narrative connections through images while still developing a vocabulary. An effective comic does not render words meaningless: picture and language compensate for one another's limitations.

Historical discussions of children's literature must treat claims about ‘the first’ comics cautiously. Contributors provide historical information, but decisive priority cannot be established without comparative catalogues of earlier periodicals, schoolbooks, popular picture series, and privately published materials. A more trustworthy conclusion is that the volume records an important stage in establishing the generic standing of Preeti Thakur's experiments with Maithili comics. Its editorial assessment can be developed through separate examinations of the original works' plots, visual composition, and language.

The Active Child Reader: From Text to Image

A particular experiment discussed by Munni Kamat in relation to Preeti Thakur's writing deserves attention: the child identifies a story, supplies a title to the image, adds dialogue, and fills in colours. The reader here is not merely a consumer but acquires the role of co-creator. Filling a story's gaps personally can encourage narrative understanding, decision-making, visual imagination, language practice, and confidence. This aspect locates comics at an intersection of childhood education and literary creation.

Yet children do not share a single age, linguistic background, or visual experience. The effectiveness of comics must therefore be tested against differences among young readerships, the clarity of pictures, ease of language, and actual responses from children. The collection provides comparatively little systematic research of this kind. Assessment often rests on adjectives such as ‘beautiful’, ‘simple’, and ‘successful’. A further critical step would be to

examine, in each comic collection, the independence of characters, women's agency, representations of caste, transformation of folk divinities, and the moral consequences of endings. This would bring the specifically literary character of Preeti Thakur's achievement into sharper focus.

Digital Maithili: Beyond Publication to Linguistic Infrastructure

The essays by Kailash Kumar Thakur and Vikas Vatsanabh do not regard digital transformation as merely a story of building websites. They jointly discuss an early internet presence, Videha's regular publication, access for established and new writers, dictionaries, experimentation with multiple scripts, and the possibility of searchable literature. Within such an infrastructure, an editor is more than someone who accepts submissions: the editor becomes an intermediary in distributing texts, building archives, and connecting communities of readers. As literary history examines the role of the printing press, so the digital age requires analysis of universally available repositories of texts and open editorial processes.

In Videha's case, multiscript publication raises an essential question about Maithili identity: language and script are not the same thing. Devanagari can expand readership, preservation of Tirhuta and Kaithi maintains links with history, and other scripts enlarge the range of linguistic expression. Yet an announcement of multiscript publication differs from practical readability. An achievement cannot be regarded as complete without evidence at the level of actual use: accurate Unicode text, standardised transliteration, printability, searchability, accessibility for readers with visual impairments, and long-term preservation.

Vikas Vatsanabh's discussion of dictionaries provides a foundation for this argument. The compilation of Maithili–English, English–Maithili, and computational terminology is connected to the practical life of a language in digital settings. Coining words is not merely a translator's problem: science education, administration, technological communication, and writers' confidence depend upon it. A modern literary history may recognise lexicographers and language technologists as contributors to the formation of a literary environment, although the linguistic accuracy of their dictionaries demands separate examination.

The Contradictions of Preserving Genealogies: Documents, Social Justice, and Rights

Bhairav Lal Das's ‘Gajendra Thakur's Contribution to Preserving Mithila's Genealogies’ is among the collection's most historically and socially complex essays. Genealogical registers provide material concerning lineages, marriage structures, family relationships, and local history; their customary uses have also been associated with caste rankings and social control. Das holds these facts together. While establishing the documentary significance of publishing genealogies, he discusses historical systems of genealogists, interventions by the Darbhanga Raj, changing marriage customs, and the physical

deterioration of manuscripts. Preservation should therefore mean safeguarding the records with historical discernment, not idealising their older social arrangements unchanged.

Particular caution is needed when discussing work published under the name ‘genome mapping’. Compiling genealogical lineages and sequencing biological genetic material are not identical methods. The designation in the volume should be understood as a publication title and in the context of genealogical research, not as automatic evidence of genetic testing. Likewise, digital availability alone does not settle the question of public access: genealogies may disclose information about living people, raise issues of privacy, risk incorrect assignment of ancestry, and reproduce caste-based exclusion. A public-interest archive fulfils its purposes only when access, contextualisation, correction, and rights are governed by clear policies.

An important strength of Das's essay is that it leaves one-sided celebration behind and confronts the economic and managerial problems of preserving genealogies. The livelihood of genealogists, transmission of local knowledge, manuscripts that are disintegrating, and the needs of Maithils living far from home are considered together. The essay supplies a method for historically sensitive reading of the collection: history cannot be separated from the society in which people live.

Commitment to the People: Diversity of Thought and Democratic Entry

Poonam Jha ‘Sudha’, in ‘Diversity and Videha’, discusses diversity across language, authorship, and subject matter. Munnaji's ‘The Scarcity of Non-Upper-Caste Writers in Maithili and Gajendra Thakur’ sharply questions caste inequality in access to literary publication. Dhanakar Thakur's ‘Videha Journal's Commitment to the People’ mediates between these perspectives through a reasoned classification. He proposes five tests: commitment in language, commitment with regard to writers' social classes, commitment in themes and genres, commitment in awards, and commitment in special issues. Such distinctions turn a largely emotive expression into a subject open to critical verification.

The most significant subtlety of Dhanakar Thakur's discussion is that he acknowledges the existence of earlier Maithili writers from non-upper-caste communities while identifying the lack of an equally receptive literary environment for them. The assertions ‘there were no writers before’ and ‘there were no adequate editorial opportunities before’ are not the same. Preserving the difference is essential to social literary history. Videha's contribution can be evaluated more accurately through this conceptual precision.

Commitment to the people cannot be measured solely by a writer's caste identity. It is also necessary to examine the representation within literary works of labour, land, women's experiences, education, economic exploitation, vernacular speech, and local justice. Shiv Kumar Prasad's extended essay connects examples of numerous writers to their works. These

examples suggest that evaluating literary representation requires both attention to the numbers of authors and to the internal forms of their writing. An inclusive journal's strength lies not merely in accommodating diverse voices but in daring to hold them to equally rigorous critical standards.

New Writers, Editorial Collaboration, and Literary Generations

Kalpana Jha's 'Videha and New Writers' places the educational role of editing at its centre. Refining a new writer's language, clarifying meaning, introducing earlier literary works, and fostering confidence before readers are forms of labour that often disappear behind a celebrated text's finished form. Kalpana Jha makes this invisible work part of literary inheritance. An important implication follows: nurturing new authors is not the displacement of older writers but the creation of a living conversation between inherited tradition and experiment.

Kundan Karn's brief autobiographical account turns this general argument into an engaging personal illustration. He describes his development as an emerging writer through writing on social media, contact with Munnaji, and an introduction to the journal. Its importance goes beyond homage: it gives a glimpse of the social processes by which writers are formed. Nevertheless, one person's experience cannot establish a universal account of all authors. A more comprehensive study would need to collect early publications, editorial exchanges, revised texts, and material from subsequent books.

Historical comparison here brings into view Maithili traditions of edited journals, village literary gatherings, school publications, and literary assemblies. Videha is not an entirely disconnected new creation but a digital extension of these traditions with a different social structure. Its differences lie in the speed of circulation, durable access, connections with migrant readers, and conversations across geography. Attending to both continuity and difference produces a more capable historiography.

The Theory of Criticism: Commitment and Closeness to the Text

Hitnath Jha's 'Gajendra Thakur and Maithili Literary Criticism' identifies forms of intellectual labour: discussions of short narrative forms, miniature stories, ghazals, haiku, prosody, verbal usage, and criticism of prose and verse. Quoting another work, the essay presents an important principle: 'A writer's ideology should be like salt in water, not oil in water.' As cited by Hitnath Jha, the statement means that ideology should dissolve into a work's meanings rather than form an external coating over its autonomous sensibility.

Yet 'ideology' and 'impartiality' should not be understood as a simple pair of opposites. Every critical act begins with certain questions, interests, values, or social experiences. Responsible criticism makes these premises transparent and substantiates its judgements through language, imagery, structure, plot, character, metre, or evidence. Hitnath Jha's study illuminates the need for

genre-specific critical instruments in Maithili; evaluating their practical success, however, requires independent close readings.

At this point the book's metaphor enters into an interesting relation with critical method. An inclusive editor has a responsibility to publish articles expressing divergent views; a critic has no duty to declare every view equally valid, but must judge on evidence. 'Setusham' contributes precisely through this difficult coexistence: gathering different authorial perspectives while allowing readers to recognise the distinctions between them.

History, Dictionaries, and Multilingual Modernity

In Praveen Kumar Jha's biographical-literary account and Ujjwal Kumar Jha's discussion of cultural renewal, Gajendra Thakur appears as writer, editor, historian, lexicographer, and investigator of scripts. A common aim can be seen across these fields: not to sever the continuity of older knowledge, and not to allow a language's future to narrow for lack of modern resources. Manuscript preservation, dictionary making, translation, and digital publication are distinct kinds of labour. It would therefore be misleading to merge them into one generic celebration of an individual. Each demands its own technical evidence, practices of error correction, and tests of usefulness for readers.

Studies available in Videha's research index, including 'A Parallel History of Maithili Literature', 'A Critical Theory of Children's Novels in Maithili', and 'A Parallel Grammar, Composition and Linguistics of Maithili', show how this many-sided project extends through a series of texts. Their titles alone suggest an attempt to consider alternative readerships rather than confining literature to prestigious genres or one standard form of language. Their presence in a research catalogue does not, however, establish the quality of the works. That requires independent evaluation.

In the context of multilingual modernity, differences between Maithili experience in Nepal and India must also be remembered. Kailash Kumar Thakur's essay strongly conveys Nepalese experiences of Maithili usage, schooling, and pressure from state languages. Editorial notes explain these linguistic differences to readers. The point is that standardisation and correctness should not turn into enforced uniformity: the actual vocabulary and social situations of writers across the border deserve a place in the history of contemporary Maithili literature.

Absence from the Stage: An Alternative Understanding of the Literary Public Sphere

Mukesh Anand's 'Gajendra Thakur's Absence from Literary Platforms in Mithila and among Maithils: Causes and Effects' is the final principal essay of the collection. Its tone differs from that of many celebratory contributions. It raises uncomfortable questions about literary events, the politics of personal acquaintance, desires for honours, factional associations, and deficiencies in

readers' judgement. The writer argues that sustained creative labour and regular appearances on public platforms are not identical. In this context 'absence' becomes less a negative void than the possibility of independent space for literary work.

Distance from literary platforms nevertheless cannot itself serve as the only evidence of ethical superiority. Literary gatherings offer direct readings, collective learning, and opportunities for argument; digital forums may complement rather than merely replace them. The essential question is how transparent such institutions are in their decisions, distribution of opportunities, and criticism. The standards applied to traditional institutions must also be applied to alternatives. Such symmetry would strengthen the book's intellectual credibility.

The Language of Praise and the Seriousness of Evidence

Essays by Jagadanand Jha 'Manu', Kundan Karn, and Ujjwal Kumar Jha contain numerous comparisons invoking extraordinary effort, incomparable service, and the shaping of an era. Such images have a social purpose: they make overlooked labour visible and produce a sense of respect. But 'unique', 'first', 'peerless', and 'epoch-making figure' cannot suffice for scholarly judgement. Decisive claims require bibliographies, publication records, comparisons with earlier works, dated evidence, and direct examples from texts. The volume does not consistently apply these standards with equal rigour.

An abundance of praise is itself a literary symptom. Where communities feel a lack of institutional recognition, sympathetic criticism may adopt the language of building an exemplary figure. Consequently, contradictions, shortcomings in form, or the limits of an author's ideas can be displaced from consideration. 'Setusham' also contains essays with searching questions that counterbalance this tendency. Its fullest value emerges when the reader treats praise and questioning as mutually corrective.

Close Readings: Four Critical Centres

A close reading of the editorial introduction places the 'bridge' at its first centre. Its primary meanings are to connect what is separate, cross an obstacle, and make a journey possible. From the introduction to the chapter organisation, this image is transformed from a religious allusion into a social action. It is easy to compare literary institutions to the two banks of a river, but the metaphor becomes effective when it raises questions: which banks have been connected, who remains unable to cross, and which social conditions make passage difficult? The title thus becomes a source of critical inquiry in its own right.

The second centre is the textual nature of Preeti Thakur's comics. Narrative here unfolds not only in words but in visual sequence. When Gonu Jha's ingenuity reaches children through pictures, it does more than produce

humour: it offers a visual representation of folk knowledge. The creative representation of stories from 'Purush Pariksha' effects a particular change by transforming materials from a learned tradition into reading for children. Such transformations, however, require reconsideration of the source stories' unexamined assumptions concerning violence, caste, female characters, education, or morality. Without independently examining the original children's books, the present discussion can identify interpretive possibilities, not pronounce a final judgement.

The third centre is Bhairav Lal Das's essay, whose special quality is to connect documentary material with social processes. Discussing genealogies in relation to caste restrictions, genealogists' livelihoods, and changing forms of marriage reveals history together with its contradictions. The fourth centre is Dhanakar Thakur's essay, which divides commitment to the people into five criteria and turns editorial celebration into analysis. These two essays are particularly compelling examples of the critical possibilities within the collection.

Together, the four centres delineate the collection's central concerns: metaphor, visual storytelling, documents, and institutional ethics. They move beyond a conventional 'author–work' relation to establish the many-sided relationship of 'author–medium–society–reader'. At this level, 'Setusham' has the potential to become more than a tribute centred on individuals.

A Comparative Place in the History of Maithili Literature

Jyotirishwar's prose, Vidyapati's poetry, and the long tradition of folk narratives provide different foundations for Maithili literary expression. In earlier periods, circulation depended on complex relationships among manuscripts, singers, reading communities, courts, and local patrons. The development of modern printing and periodicals established new relations between literature and its audiences. Digital publication may be read as a third social stage, in which writing can travel great distances almost immediately and older materials can be retrieved with greater ease. This is not a straightforward narrative of 'progress' but a history of the advantages and losses associated with different media.

Most essays in 'Setusham' connect an author's creative activity with the history of literary dissemination. The volume can thus be regarded as a source for the institutional history of modern Maithili literature. Unlike a direct assessment of poems or stories, it finds literary value not only in the verbal beauty of creative writing but in editing, collecting, standardising, training, and work concerning language policy. A historically balanced comparison nevertheless cannot exclude earlier periodicals, printed anthologies, Maithili editing in Nepal, women's writing, or informal community platforms.

Dhanakar Thakur's recollection of the development of Maithili periodicals pays particular attention to 'Mithila Mihir'. It makes clear that the writer himself measures the new work against an older editorial tradition. Modernity should therefore not be reduced to a claim that 'everything earlier was a void

and everything now is new'. The significance of fresh contributions emerges from sound analysis of their relations with earlier traditions and their capacity to transform them.

Parallel Literary History: Achievements and Cautions

An important purpose of parallel history is to discover sources absent from established bibliographies and academic maps. Rural writers, authors from non-upper-caste communities, migrant readers, traditions of Tirhuta and Kaithi scripts, women's literature for children, local ballads, and multilingual communities across borders collectively widen the scope of literary history. 'Setusham' is a social document of such an attempt. The repeated account of opening institutional doors is itself worthy of study.

Writing a parallel history nevertheless also risks producing an alternative centre of power. Opposing older standards is insufficient: we must examine whether new standards are themselves open, self-critical, and faithful to evidence. For example, resistance to caste exclusion must be accompanied by questions about the neglect of women's writing, weak documentation, editorial bias, or one-sided representations of rival institutions. Through such self-criticism, parallel literary history can move beyond proclamations of resistance and become a trustworthy instrument of knowledge.

The Collection's Critical Limitations and Prospects for Research

Several systematic limitations emerge from a reading of the entire collection. Extended formal close readings of Preeti Thakur's children's fiction are scarce. Despite the immense range of Gajendra Thakur's writing, discussions of editing and cultural service exceed close readings of poetry, stories, and plays. Many claims of being the 'first' or 'only' example of an institutional achievement require survey-based evidence. Some contributors offer independent documentation, while others rely on personal recollections; the book often places these differing sources within an apparently uniform reading structure. More explicit classification of sources and examination of conflicting testimony would have been useful.

A second limitation concerns the critical idiom. Elevated praise and emotional metaphors express a community's gratitude, but their overuse may make evaluation of the works difficult. A third concerns institutional self-description: cooperation between authors, editors, and those celebrated is an important fact, but it cannot replace independent external scrutiny. A fourth lies in historical method: considerable comparative research remains possible on earlier women's literature, book culture, caste and class diversity, literary circulation between Nepal and India, and the first experiments in writing for children.

Future scholarship could use the essays in 'Setusham' as starting points for independent readings of original works, histories of editorial documents, studies of the aesthetics of comics, the social history of genealogies, and

research into the networks of authors who contribute to digital journals. Such undertakings demand comparison of different forms of evidence, not merely sympathetic or antagonistic readings. The collection's lasting usefulness may be that it gives subsequent critics questions to investigate, writers to discover, and points of entry into sources.

Conclusion: Building Bridges, Testing Bridges

Two propositions hold simultaneously in an integrated assessment of 'Setusham: Vibrant Maithili'. First, it is an important document of the modern Maithili public sphere, assembling discussions of women's work in comics, emerging writers, digital libraries, language technology, genealogical archives, multiscript experiments, popular commitment, and new critical tools. Second, several of its essays are not equally rigorous in defining achievements or supporting claims with evidence. To treat the book as a triumph beyond criticism would therefore diminish its genuine research value.

The volume's most fruitful gift is the question implied by the 'bridge'. Whom does it connect? Who still lacks access? How trustworthy and useful is the knowledge made public? Can the memory of an author's contribution withstand literary self-criticism? Seeking answers moves literary history beyond the confines of hero-worship or opposition to institutions. 'Setusham' may acquire lasting importance because it offers materials for understanding new literary structures in Maithili, while a critical reading insists on making those structures more just, better evidenced, and more inclusive.

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PART II

The Ghazal: Craft, Society, and Poetic Language

Rereading Maithili Literature

REVIEW 7

Anchinhar Akhar

Disciplined Ghazal Craft and a Commitment to Ordinary People

Abstract

Ashish Anchinhar's 'Anchinhar Akhar' (2011) marks a development in the modern Maithili ghazal in which creative experimentation and the examination of a genre's own principles become mutually supportive. The collection comprises seventy-eight ghazals, thirty-two *rubaiyat*, and two *qitas*. Before presenting these works, the author considers the history of the ghazal and the relationships among the *matla*, *maqta*, *qafiya*, *radif*, *bahr*, pronunciation, and the sound system of Maithili. This study separately examines the social, economic, political, erotic, and self-reflexive dimensions of the collection. Farmers' land, inflation, hunger, parliamentary ineffectiveness, political opportunism, appeals of love, and the ghazal's self-consciousness together form a shared poetic terrain. Historical comparison suggests that the development of the Maithili ghazal is not simply a question of adopting an external Arabic–Persian–Urdu structure, but of making Maithili pronunciation, vocabulary, and social experience feel natural within that structure. The study also assesses the limitations posed by repetition, conventional imagery, direct assertion, and insistence on formal discipline.

Keywords: Maithili ghazal; Ashish Anchinhar; qafiya; radif; bahr; rubai; qita; social satire; poetry committed to ordinary people; Maithili literary history.

1. Introduction: A Creative Dialogue Between Language and Discipline

The Maithili poetic tradition possesses a long history of song, lyric, folk melodies, and metre. The entry and independent identification of the ghazal raise another question: when an external literary form enters a local language, does it merely preserve its technical structure, or does it acquire new forms under pressure from the new language's pronunciation, cultural memory, and experience? 'Anchinhar Akhar' offers a concrete creative response. On the one hand, the poet takes the grammar of the ghazal seriously; on the other, he

gives a place within the ghazal to the local worlds of earth, fields, hunger, government, darkness, mind, tears, and love.

The title itself is suggestive. ‘Anchinhar’ may refer to an unrecognised or unidentified voice speaking from beyond established literary taste and elite-centred discourse. ‘Akhar’ (‘letters’ or ‘words’) provides a basis not only for language but for writing, resistance, memory, and identity. Such possible meanings should be recognised as a reader-centred critical interpretation, not as an explicit declaration by the author.

The publication details identify Ashish Anchinhar as author, Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, as publisher, 2011 as the year of the first edition, and ISBN 978-93-80538-48-8. The English description of the title likewise identifies the book as a collection of Maithili ghazals, rubaiyat, and qitas. The collection shows itself to be not simply a book of poems but an early document of debate about poetic genres.

The chief basis of the present discussion is the collection's creative writing and the author's introductory reflections. The Videha book collection, research index, and available critical materials published by Videha are used for background on literary history, bibliographies, and subsequent debates about the ghazal. Unrelated websites or unsupported conjecture have not been substituted for evidence.

2. The Collection's Organisation and Poetic Intent

The ordering of the book deserves attention. An extended discussion of the history and grammar of the ghazal is followed by a dedication, the sequence of poems, ghazals, rubaiyat, and qitas. This arrangement brings readers into the grammatical world of the genre before they begin experiencing the poems. Education in form and poetic experience are not separate projects here, but two foundations of a single literary undertaking.

The seventy-eight ghazals encompass a wide range of moods and subjects. Several early pieces attack power, exploitation, and inequality; poems in the middle of the collection more frequently engage love, separation, relationships, nature, and creative self-awareness; in the closing group, social criticism again acquires urgency. The sequence is not wholly linear, and this shifting movement brings out the relative independence characteristic of individual ghazal couplets.

The thirty-two rubaiyat take the collection's emotional range into compact four-line forms. The two qitas concern love, beauty, and mythological correspondences. Thus, while principally centred on the ghazal, the book also makes room for the independent possibilities of other brief poetic forms.

3. The Introductory Account of Genre: History, Grammar, and Pronunciation

The author's ‘A Brief Introduction to the Ghazal’ traces a progression through the Arabic *qasida*, the Persian ghazal, the Urdu poetic tradition,

and the arrival of the form in Maithili. Mentioning Imru' al-Qays, Rudaki, Saadi, Hafiz, Amir Khusro, Mir, and Ghalib, the author situates the ghazal within a multilingual history. In the Maithili context, the reference to Kaviwar Jeevan Jha's 'Sundar Sanyog' is particularly important. It should be received as the author's historical argument; it would be unjustified to regard every intermediate historical claim in this brief essay as fully established by independent evidence.

The treatment of technical terms—*matla*, *maqta*, *sher*, *misra*, *radif*, *qafiya*, non-*musalsal* ghazal, *musalsal* ghazal, *bahr*, and *takhallus*—reveals serious concern with craft. Importantly, the author does not mechanically reproduce Arabic and Persian prescriptions. He also considers Maithili's tendency to attach case endings, the use of the anusvara and chandrabindu, conjunct consonants, distinctions between short and long vowels in spelling and speech, and practical problems of metrical equivalence.

The poet argues that one cannot determine a *qafiya* without understanding a language's forms and the flow of its spoken sounds. This matters because the grammar of the ghazal does not regard Maithili as a passive language that merely imitates others, but recognises it as a creative language possessing its own phonological system. Reconciliation of formal accuracy with local pronunciation is one of the book's most valuable intellectual contributions.

Nevertheless, it would be mistaken to assume that every rule advanced in the introduction is universally applicable, indisputable, or a definitive linguistic conclusion. Examples of pronunciation, classifications of traditional metres, and limits of linguistic practice demand different forms of evidence. The value of the discussion as literary theory is clear; independently testing each technical rule and scanning each couplet would constitute a separate study.

4. Close Readings of Selected Ghazals

4.1. Ghazal 1: Capital, Display, and the Devaluation of Humanity

'For the sake of wealth, people became entangled in a web of possessions.' (Ghazal 1)

The first ghazal establishes the collection's ideological orientation. The verbal closeness of *mal* ('wealth') and *mal-jal* ('a snare of possessions') constructs a net of economic greed within human life. Images of hunger, display, social conduct, and self-distortion are interconnected. The poet does not merely describe poverty; he attacks the process through which wealth becomes a regulator of personality, ethics, and human relationships. The recurrence of *lok* ('people') turns individual wrongdoing into a collective tendency. The couplet illustrates how ordinary spoken vocabulary can generate extensive meanings.

4.2. Ghazal 16: Political Darkness and Satire's Double Voice

'A blind government, indeed, is running the affairs of state.' (Ghazal 16)

The ending of the second line, 'All else is well', becomes a persistent satirical conclusion. The poet superimposes political illness upon the language of welfare and well-being familiar from news and letters. 'Blind government' simultaneously suggests moral blindness, failed policy, and public irresponsibility. Each repetition of 'All else is well' converts an ordinary assurance into bitter irony. The poetic power derives from the transformed meaning of the *radif*: the same words produce distrust rather than confidence.

4.3. Ghazal 23: A Ghazal about the Ghazal Itself

'A ghazal of life's happiness, a ghazal of life's pain.' (Ghazal 23)

This may be read as a self-reflexive proclamation about the form. The ghazal is no longer merely the language of love, but a medium through which the whole of life's happiness and suffering can be voiced. Images of the Himalayas, fire, and resistance connect the ghazal with internal resolve and social heat. As a self-referential poem, it sometimes becomes a celebration of its own genre. Yet the poet's artistic commitment is evident within this affirmation: to establish the Maithili ghazal beyond a narrowly erotic genre as a form capable of encompassing the social life of ordinary people.

4.4. Ghazal 26: The Humble Grammar of Address and Intimacy

'Give me a place within your eyes; / Conceal me within your breath.' (Ghazal 26)

The repetition of 'take me in' in the opening couplet becomes a gentle plea for proximity to the beloved. Images of eyes and breath bring both seeing and living within the realm of love. Rather than demanding possession, the speaker asks to be accepted. This poem also appears as an example in the introductory discussion of the ghazal, creating a direct bridge between composition and grammatical explanation. Technically, the repeated request is more than an ornament of sound: it forms the emotional centre of the relationship.

4.5. Ghazal 31: Land, Ideology, and the Changing Meaning of War

'War over earth, water, and air; / Look, war even over the smallest matter.' (Ghazal 31)

'Earth, water, and air' form a list of the fundamental conditions of human existence. In the second line, linking something as slight as a 'small matter' with the severe word 'war' exposes political and social incongruity. The poem proceeds to questions of ideals and ideology, property and land, and relationships. Although the repetition of 'war' provides a semantic centre, it risks dependence on a monotonous proclamation. The poet's attempt to connect ordinary things with ideological struggle is nevertheless notable.

4.6. Ghazal 48: The Interlinked Images of Darkness, Farmers, and Hunger

'People travel towards the city of darkness in search of light; / In dreams, they eat rice made only of dreams.' (Ghazal 48)

These lines provide a particularly sharp instance of the poet's gifts. In the first, the direction of the search for light has been reversed: people head towards a city of darkness. In the second, rice—the most elementary sustenance—is displaced from reality into a dream. The condition of eating in a dream renders the social reality of hunger poignant through exaggeration. The ghazal also refers to fields, exploitation, famine, and working lives. The opposed pairs of light and darkness, rice and dream, combine into a metaphor for political failure.

4.7. Ghazal 60: Inflation and the Irony of Public Representation

'One day we shall see gold cheap and rice expensive.' (Ghazal 60)

The ordering of value is inverted. Gold is conventionally a luxury, while rice is a necessity of daily life; the poet reverses their relative affordability. This is not simply the rhetorical figure of reversal, but a question of food security and unequal distribution. References to the Lok Sabha, legislative assemblies, and a hungry population test the public responsibilities of the machinery of power. The poem occasionally approaches the slogan, but its underlying satire arises from a recognisable social experience.

4.8. Ghazal 70: The Language of Development and Public Despondency

'Development in newspaper headlines, and a despondent people.' (Ghazal 70)

The line turns on 'newspaper development': progress that gleams in the news system's headlines while its fruits remain absent from everyday life. The words 'despondent people' place lived experience against the artificial announcement of success. By carrying everyday political vocabulary into a formally crafted couplet, the poet alters the mode of public debate. Poetry becomes not a memorandum of argument but a linguistic response from the public imagination.

5. The Texture of Love and Separation: Eyes, Mind, Breath, and Body

The form of address *ahan* ('you', respectful and intimate) is central to Anchinhar's love ghazals. Between the first person *ham* ('I') and the second person *ahan*, distance, appeal, shyness, affection, and at times helplessness continually change their configuration. The vocabulary of eyes, tears, lips, breath, mind, heart, and dreams gives love a tender physical presence. These are familiar words of spoken Maithili, not substitutes drawn from an imported poetic diction.

In Ghazal 26 love takes the form of a plea for acceptance; Ghazal 43 presents everyday remembrance and return; Ghazal 59 makes even a quarrel a form of intimacy; Ghazal 61 combines love, dreams, and the *takhallus* to create a self-conscious voice. In these situations, the poet does not treat love

merely as bodily attachment, but as the language of relationships, remembrance, and private vulnerability.

The system of love imagery nevertheless frequently returns to familiar symbols such as the rose, wine, eyes, and lips. Their accessibility draws readers closer but does not always produce a fresh aesthetic experience. The poet's distinction shines more strongly when ordinary Maithili domestic actions or locally current terms of relationship invest conventional images with new meanings.

6. A Separate Study of the Rubai: Four-Line Argument, Love, and the Philosophy of Life

6.1. Rubai 1: Optimism in Everyday Language

'With courage, one's work will always succeed; / The body will burn, but one's name will remain.' (Rubai 1)

The opening rubai concerns action, mortality, the survival of one's name, and an attitude of struggling against difficulties. Its first two lines relate life's transience to the value of action. A subsequent image of mountains of problems floating away like cotton provides a psychologically reassuring, instructive conclusion. The poem's effect rests on directness, while raising the question of how much complexity survives when difficult experience is turned into a simple maxim of encouragement.

6.2. Rubaiyat 13 and 17: Lessons of Experience and Social Irony

Rubai 13 expresses, in compressed form, the pain of broken trust. The progression through dreams, mind, and trust conveys an emotional decline within human relationships. Rubai 17 brings moral imagination, nonviolence, and the contradictions of public life into proximity. Here the poet's judgement moves beyond private love towards social satire. Both works make clear that the rubai is not simply an alternative form for love poetry in this collection, but also a platform for compact reflection on life.

6.3. Rubai 32: Love's Instability and the Opposition of Life and Death

'In love, blood will dry and turn into tears.' (Rubai 32)

This line intensifies love's emotional distress by combining physical and visual images. Blood drying and becoming tears transforms bodily experience into a metaphor for sorrow. Within four lines, the lover is surrounded by the possibilities of both life and death. The use of excessively sentimental imagery in several rubaiyat nevertheless produces predictable emotional climaxes; the form is stronger when its final line transforms the meanings established at the beginning.

7. A Separate Study of the Qitas: Wit, Beauty, and Mythic Memory

The collection's first qita is based on a questioning comparison concerning beauty. By giving greater importance to tears in the eyes and laughter on the

lips than to external bodily form, it refuses to confine beauty to the visible body. Its question-and-answer voice lends the poem the ease of everyday speech.

The second qita brings together the tree of the heart, the fragrance of love, and mythological references to the first gopi and Krishna. The experience of love is illuminated by cultural memory. The mythic comparison is better read as an analogy for private love than as a declaration of fixed models for lovers. Because of their brevity, the immediacy of expression in both qitas differs from the ghazal's more extensive emotional range.

8. Language, Voice, and Figures of Speech: The Actual Foundations of Maithilisation

In the context of the Maithili ghazal, 'Maithilisation' does not simply mean replacing a Hindi or Urdu word with a Maithili equivalent. It entails rearranging pronunciation, case endings, verb forms, modes of address, idiom, and worldly experience. Words such as *ahan*, *hamra*, *karej*, *nor*, *mon*, *ijot*, *basat*, *mati*, and *chaur* are not merely regional markers in this collection; they actively structure feeling. Through them, love speaks in the idiom of the village, and political satire approaches common experience.

The poet frequently uses opposed pairs: light and darkness, hunger and rice, gold and rice, love and separation, body and soul, government and people, dream and reality. These oppositions are simple but often achieve piercing satire. The contrast between dream and rice in Ghazal 48 and that between gold and rice in Ghazal 60 are particularly notable.

The recurring *radif* emerges as an independent instrument of meaning. In Ghazal 16, 'All else is well' becomes irony rather than reassurance; in Ghazal 26, 'take me in' expresses the sweetness of supplication; in Ghazal 60, 'we shall see one day' creates apprehension and warning about the future. These examples reveal the relationship of form to meaning.

8A. The Structure of Lyric Composition: The Autonomy of the Couplet and the Rhythm of the Whole Ghazal

Each couplet of a ghazal may be meaningful by itself, yet its *radif*, *qafiya*, and recurring rhythm connect it to the experience of the whole poem. 'Anchinhar Akhar' displays different outcomes of this relationship. In love ghazals, the refrain often sustains an intimate appeal; in political ghazals, the same device produces denial, mockery, or warning. The music of the ghazal thus arises not only from pronunciation but from changes in emotional situation.

Many of the ghazals end with an indication relating to their 'varna' or syllabic count. This expresses the poet's numerical awareness of composition. Yet number of syllables, vocal weight, and actual pronunciation are not the same. Establishing the metre of a couplet requires attending to the flow of

sounded speech, caesura, and balanced construction of every line. The historical significance of the author's insistence on metre can therefore be recognised without declaring every poem an equally accomplished instance of metrical discipline.

Another significant aspect of poetic language is the self-presentation achieved through the *takhallus*, the poet's chosen name within the ghazal. ‘Anchinhar’ is not merely a signature of identity; in many places it appears as a poetic person wounded, resistant, or filled with love. This use establishes a closeness between the poet and the speaking voice of a couplet. It would nonetheless be a literary error to equate them completely and treat the utterance as a factual account of the poet's private life.

The difference between the ghazal and the rubai is not merely the number of lines. In the ghazal, the rhythmic recurrence of individual couplets produces a multicentred web of meaning; the rubai places greater weight on the development of a statement and its final turn within four lines. Several rubaiyat in the collection conclude with a general proposition. They thus become more narrative or aphoristic than the ghazals, while the qita emerges as yet another kind of condensed experience. Reading the three forms together clarifies the distinctive characters of the author's brief poetry.

8B. Perspective and Representation: New Critical Questions Alongside Achievement

The voice opposing social injustice is a leading achievement of the collection. Yet as we examine the range of its social concerns, we must ask whether all groups are represented with equal intensity. Farmers, the poor, hungry citizens, and state repression are clearly voiced; women's independent agency, the gendered division of labour, and the complexities of caste relationships are more peripheral in many poems. This does not invalidate the poet's social commitment, but makes it legitimate to ask which experiences occupy the centre of poetry committed to the people and which remain invisible.

In the love ghazals, the beloved addressed as *ahan* usually occupies the centre of attraction, absence, memory, or anticipated response; the poetic speaker's experience is explicit. The beloved's independent self-description is comparatively rare. This should be read not as automatic proof of failure but as a critical tension between traditional address-centred love lyric and modern questions of social representation. The issue extends our reading beyond a poet's emotions to the social conditions in which those emotions are expressed.

9. A Comparative Historical Discussion: Tradition, Rereading, and Difference

9.1. The Long Tradition of Maithili Lyric and the New Grammar of the Ghazal

A major historical context for Maithili lyric is the emotional concentration, closeness to folk melody, and rhythms of address in Vidyapati's songs. The repetition of love, separation, and address in Anchinhar's ghazals allows a thematic dialogue with traditional lyric poetry. But this affinity should not be mistaken for evidence of direct influence or identical metrical ancestry. Vidyapati's songs and the ghazal have different poetics, stanzaic organisations, and musical-cultural foundations. The comparison concerns fields of meaning, not mechanical correspondence of metre.

9.2. From Jeevan Jha to the Development of the Modern Maithili Ghazal

The author mentions Kaviwar Jeevan Jha's 'Sundar Sanyog' in his introductory essay. Available critical discussions and records of edited representative anthologies within Videha identify Jeevan Jha and the early twentieth century when discussing early evidence of the Maithili ghazal. Later histories in Videha also discuss Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra 'Madhupe', Jagdishchandra Thakur 'Anil', and other poetic experiments. Caution is necessary here: conventional judgements of priority and chronology may change as fresh evidence becomes available.

Jeevan Jha's place primarily raises a question of historical beginnings; Anchinhar's collection introduces the further question of self-consciousness about the genre. At one point, the existence of the ghazal is a matter of history; at another, developing a metrical grammar adapted to the language becomes an act of critical consciousness. 'Anchinhar Akhar' is therefore better understood not as the necessarily first point of the history, but as an influential modern representative of formal reflection.

9.3. Arabic–Persian–Urdu Poetic Organisation and Maithili Folk Experience

In Arabic, Persian, and Urdu ghazal traditions, the independence of each couplet, repetition of *radif* and *qafiya*, use of the *takhallus*, and regularity of *bahr* are defining formal expectations. Anchinhar adopts these technical concepts without suppressing the difficulties posed by Maithili pronunciation. His method therefore gives a place within one critical discussion to both formal continuity and linguistic difference.

Thematic comparison may recall the broad traditions of Ghalib's introspection, love and separation in the Urdu ghazal, and political questions in modern socially committed ghazals. But declaring Ghazals 16, 48, and 60 mere replicas of a particular Urdu or Hindi poet would subordinate the distinctive Maithili experiences they express. Anchinhar's strongest couplets arise where established ghazal craft is transformed by the local experiences embodied in Maithili vocabulary.

9.4. Later Debates in Videha

Videha's research indexes record essays by Ashish Anchinhar titled ‘Qafiya’, ‘Qafiya and Bahr’, ‘Early Experiments with the Grammar of the Maithili Ghazal’, ‘A Brief Critical Introduction to the Modern Maithili Ghazal’, ‘The Maithili Ghazal in the Context of Expression’, and ‘A Comparative Discussion of Narendraji's Maithili and Hindi Ghazals’. These recorded titles are sufficient to show that the formal problems encountered in the collection subsequently became subjects of independent criticism. Further conclusions would require examination of the full texts of those essays.

An extended assessment by Gajendra Thakur available through Videha places Ashish Anchinhar within the wider settings of the Maithili ghazal movement, poetic discipline, and editing. That evaluation may be regarded as evidence of contemporary reception, but no final decision about the book's artistic qualities can rest on prestige or praise alone. It must arise from direct readings of the poems.

10. Aesthetic Achievements and Critical Limitations

The first achievement is an expanded social range. The ghazal moves beyond its conventionally restricted expectations when personal pain in love appears alongside hunger, agricultural crisis, parliamentary politics, and the moral disintegration of human beings. The second achievement is technical self-awareness: the author raises formal difficulties himself and seeks solutions grounded in Maithili phonetic experience. The third is a vocabulary close to ordinary people, in which grave emotions are frequently expressed through familiar domestic and regional words.

The principal limitation emerges when a ghazal couplet presents a political assertion with little more than end-rhyme. Words like ‘government’, ‘people’, ‘development’, and ‘corruption’ undoubtedly denote social realities, but their presence in every couplet cannot automatically produce a poetic revelation. Where they establish fresh relations among image, scene, and meaning, the poetry succeeds; where they remain merely declarative, the art is weaker.

A second limitation is the recurrence of conventional love imagery. Associations of eyes and wine, or face and rose, appear in more than one rubai. Such repetition supports lyrical familiarity and recognisable beauty but restricts semantic freshness. In this respect, the collection's achievements also disclose possibilities for more rigorous self-editing.

A third question concerns formal correctness. The author's account of the ghazal emphasises *bahr* and *qafiya*, yet independently scanning every couplet is necessary to demonstrate successful metrical discipline throughout. This study makes no claim of universal correctness on the basis of the text available to it. The aesthetic value of a poem and its technical conformity to poetic rules are related but not identical questions.

Finally, calling poetry ‘committed to ordinary people’ does not place it beyond criticism. Social commitment, originality of feeling, tension within

the couplet, verbal concision, naturalness of sound, and creative use of contradiction all require separate examination. ‘Anchinhar Akhar’ offers ample material for such a many-sided assessment.

11. Conclusion: Establishing the Ghazal in Maithili's Social and Linguistic Geography

The importance of ‘Anchinhar Akhar’ lies in the author's desire not merely to adopt the ghazal as an imported poetic form but to make it at home in Maithili. His introduction makes its poetics available to public discussion; the ghazals bring hunger, political resistance, and love together in one poetic sphere; the rubaiyat and qitas offer distinct experiences of shorter forms.

The most effective pieces are those in which utterance and form transform one another: ‘All else is well’ becomes political satire; ‘rice made of dreams’ becomes an unbearable symbol of hunger; ‘we shall see one day’ becomes a forewarning of future crisis; and ‘take me in’ becomes love's hesitant aspiration. The collection's real achievement lies in these poetic transformations.

Historically, the collection is not the sole birthplace of the Maithili ghazal, but an important document of the genre's modern self-examination. Linguistically, it provides a legitimate place within ghazal craft for Maithili pronunciation, case inflections, and folk vocabulary. Critically, it deserves both appreciation and questioning. Such a dialectical assessment shows that Ashish Anchinhar's contribution is not simply the writing of ghazals but the beginning of a sustained debate about the conditions for their composition and their possibilities in Maithili.

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REVIEW 8

Janghajori

The Discipline of Bahr and Resistance in Everyday Life

Abstract

'Janghajori' is a collection of two hundred ghazals by Ashish Anchinhar. Its literary importance lies not merely in a Maithili poet's engagement with a form renowned for its discipline, but also in the incorporation of Mithila's colloquial speech, bodily love, the deprivation of working communities, contradictions in political institutions, and social hypocrisy into the ghazal's compact, repetitive, suggestive structure. The poet's introductory statement raises questions concerning *bahr*, *qafiya*, *radif*, musical performance, and readers' construction of meaning. The collection therefore demands to be read as both poetry and a declaration about poetics. This study separately analyses the language, themes, images, rhythms, and satire of its ghazals, and measures the collection's contribution and limitations against accounts of the ghazal's history associated with Videha. Its conclusion is that Anchinhar's accomplishment lies in joining traditional formal discipline to a modernity grounded in the vernacular, while the distance between declared generic intentions and poetic achievement requires critical examination.

Keywords: Maithili ghazal; Ashish Anchinhar; Janghajori; bahr; radif and qafiya; satire; vernacular language; construction of meaning by readers; Videha literary movement.

Introduction: The Book, Its Organisation, and Critical Questions

A fierce contradiction operates at the creative centre of ‘Janghajori’: the external construction proclaims exceptional discipline, while the inner voice continually interrogates power, propriety, politeness, and social hierarchy. The collection comprises two hundred consecutive ghazals, each accompanied by information about the syllabic or metrical pattern. This design opens two routes through the poetry: emotional reception and formal scrutiny. Their convergence is the critical point of entry into the book.

The word ‘Janghajori’ itself evokes the bodily directness and humour of everyday speech. By its title, the collection turns away from the conventional elevation of high poetry and adopts the boldness of colloquial expression. It is insufficient, however, to call this boldness mere provocation; the intention of the title is better understood through the relations among bodily awareness, satire, and self-mockery within the book. When a brief poem presents a large political proposition, the title's apparent abruptness becomes an aesthetic indication as well.

In his account, the poet identifies his original name as Ashish Kumar Mishra, his village as Bhatra Ghat in Bisfi, Madhubani, and his editorial involvement with the ghazal-oriented web magazine ‘Anchinhar Akhar’. He describes ‘Janghajori’ as his second collection of ghazals, following ‘Anchinhar Akhar’, and notes an interval of approximately nine years. This first-person testimony illuminates his development as a practitioner, although it cannot replace a full comparison of the texts of both collections.

The Poet's Statement: Form, Discipline, and the Reader

‘Anchinhar's Words’ is not merely the book's preface; it functions as a manifesto for the ghazal. The poet connects the right to call a composition a ghazal with adherence to *bahr*, *qafiya*, and *radif*. In his view, emotion and metre are not alternatives: a powerful experience requires an appropriate poetic form. His argument is compelling in its refusal to take the easy course of treating the absence of metrical discipline as novelty. Yet the language sometimes becomes so categorical that the space needed for independent evaluation of other poetic arrangements may be restricted.

The introduction challenges the assumption that singing and the ghazal are synonymous. It emphasises the singer's independent musical labour, specialised knowledge, and the genre's literary identity. This distinction is significant: printed poetry, stage recitation, and musical performance do not share one identical aesthetic standard. Yet the very possibility that a particular ghazal cannot be sung should not be treated as proof of superior formal accomplishment. The difference must be borne in mind when reading the poet's argument.

The poet describes ‘entertainment’ as his stated purpose, yet his ghazals frequently address political disappointment, child labour, class differences, religious hypocrisy, and ordinary injustice. Entertainment consequently becomes for him not an escape from social reality but a way of confronting it through satire and aesthetic pleasure. The reader thus extends the author's declared limits through the act of reading itself.

The author's thoughts on the plurality of readers' meanings deserve particular attention. He argues that a poem written in plain language may have one immediately comprehensible meaning, while other meanings emerge through the reader's experience, time, and state of mind. To make this principle useful in criticism, interpretations must remain connected to a poem's words, context, and structure; otherwise any uncontrolled imposition of meaning could pass for plurality. Many of the best couplets in ‘Janghajori’ are suitable tests of this balance.

Ghazal Composition: Bahr, Repetition, and the Autonomy of the Couplet

The most visible mark of the collection's formal discipline is the numerical pattern printed at the close of its ghazals. Some use short, rapidly moving lines; others breathe more expansively. The author also mentions licence concerning short and long syllables, deliberate shortening of long sounds, and *bahr-e-Mir*. This printed information offers readers a beginning for metrical examination. A declared pattern alone, however, cannot prove perfect conformity; pronunciation of every *misra*, the practical lengths of sounds, established refrains and rhymes, and the permissible extent of licence require testing.

The independent semantic possibilities of the couplet are particularly strong here. Images of politics, love, nature, and bitter private experience may collide unexpectedly within one ghazal. This organisation corresponds to the traditional couplet-centred nature of the form. Where each couplet is relatively self-contained, a broad vision can emerge despite the absence of one continuous theme. Its central characteristic is the ability to seize contradiction within a very brief statement.

Repetition of the *radif* gives the poet's language a rhythmic insistence. Phrases such as ‘dunnu dissan’ (‘from both sides’), ‘kekaro nai’ (‘nobody's’), ‘kichhu bat’ (‘something to say’), and ‘pasi chhai’ connect distinct emotional terrains. The sound that returns in each couplet creates expectation; *qafiya* and *radif* are most successful together when the repeated line acquires a new significance. In the strongest ghazals, the semantic effect of recurrence changes; in weaker ones, it becomes merely predictable sound.

Individual Close Readings: The Two Sides of Relationships and the Reach of Irony

'Hands Reached Out from Both Sides': Contact and Crisis

'Hands reached out from both sides; / Steps were taken from both sides.'

The opening couplet conveys a movement of two parties towards one another. Hands and steps suggest social contact; the first impression is of union. Later, however, the same repeated phrase is associated with the kicks of democracy, the entrapment of crowds, and people's flight after a breached embankment. One *radif* first promises connection and then conveys the experience of both sides being overwhelmed by crisis. The plurality of meaning arises not from an obscure word but from a change of subject within a repeated grammatical structure.

The proximity of bodily intimacy, political failure, and environmental danger in the ghazal is not merely coincidental. 'From both sides' refers to both ends of a relationship. Power may be unequal at the two ends, but the consequences may be shared. The autonomy of its couplets thus contributes to an integrated moral scene.

'What Is Misfortune for Me': The Compressed Arithmetic of Inequality

'What is misfortune for me / is convenience for them.'

The two-line comparison immediately exposes unequal class relations. The crisis of one person or group becomes an opportunity for another. The pronouns 'me' and 'them' transcend particular individuals and stand for economic and political structures. Rather than providing a complicated theory of exploitation, the poet presents its result in a comparative sentence. The meaning readily extends to crowds, resource distribution, markets, and relations of power.

The couplet's force lies not only in the idea but in the severity of its opening proposition. Readers who recognise their own misfortunes in it can construct particular meanings. Yet this interpretive plurality does not dissolve its basic ethical equation.

Political Satire: Verbal Blows and the Limits of Resistance

'I Am a Shape-Shifting Media': Enacting Institutional Confession

'I am the shape-shifting media; / I am the corporate world's grandchild.'

The media speaks here as though reciting its own genealogy. The mythic-folkloric connotations of *ichchhadhari*, a being able to assume desired forms, collide with modern corporate relations. The poet turns an institution meant to inform the public into a creature that alters its shape for self-interest. 'Grandchild' is an intimate kinship term that describes dependence between capital and news as though it were a family relationship. The innovation lies less in the political allegation than in the vernacular, satirical construction of the charge.

Throughout the ghazal, the repeated ‘I am’ becomes a confession. Rather than criticising the institution from outside, the poet makes it testify against itself. This dramatic voice gives the satire much of its distinctive strength.

‘It Is Daytime, Yet Still So Dark’: Religious Spectacle and Civic Darkness

> *‘In a country where rape is all around, / the miracles of religion are celebrated in abundance.’*

The couplet's impact comes from a hard contradiction: social violence coexists with the public celebration of religious miracles. The conditional phrasing ‘in the country where …, in that country …’ turns the sentence into a satirical tribunal. The implied question is not whether religious experience has any value, but why spectacular miracles take the place of ethical accountability. The poem exposes the coexistence of ostentation and social brutality.

The poet discusses particular metrical licences at the conclusion of this ghazal. Forceful political meaning and impeccable metrical discipline should therefore not be assumed to constitute a self-evident unity. Evaluating both keeps questions of aesthetic effect and formal discipline in view.

‘Development for Them, Despondency for the People’: Minimal Resistance to Proclamation

> *‘Development belongs to them; / the people remain despondent.’*

Four words in the original raise doubts about the powerful's story of progress. The restricted beneficiaries signalled by ‘them’ stand in direct ideological opposition to the much larger community called ‘the people’. The lines' pathos comes not from extended metaphor but from sharp verbal minimalism. The ghazal goes on to suggest the moral decline of Parliament and public institutions. Such a brief poem can remain immediately memorable, although declarative concision may sometimes diminish the complexities of social reality.

Labour, Childhood, and Class: Brief Documents of Social Reality

‘The Poor Child Became a Servant’: Childhood Displaced

> *‘The poor child became a servant / in hotels, motels, and brick kilns.’*

‘Hotels, motels, and brick kilns’ appear not simply as a list of locations but as a continuous geography of labour. Poverty has displaced the child's life from school and play into commercial workplaces. ‘Poor child’ is not an elaborate symbol but a scene readily visible in society. The poet's realism here does not burden its subject with excess adjectives.

Another couplet juxtaposes the sweetness of life with its sudden souring. The use of taste to describe life brings childhood's transience into collision with the harshness of labour. The brick kiln gives the poem a local rural-industrial setting, while its question is much wider: who determines the worth of the most vulnerable lives amid proclaimed development?

'Fit Neither for Courtyard nor Veranda': Poverty's Exclusion from Custom

'A poor boy, just like a poor girl, / deemed fit neither for marriage nor for its rituals.'

Poor girls and boys are both treated here as bodies excluded from social rites. Marriage and *chuman*, a ceremonial blessing, become forms of recognition conditioned upon economic standing. The poem reveals the gendered dimensions of class distress without resolving them. In the voice of the rejected, it records the moral poverty of society. It is among the most direct challenges to the collection's declared aim of 'mere entertainment'.

Body, Affection, and Female Characters: The Strength of Feeling and Asymmetry of Perspective

'In That Hand, the Body Is a Flower': The Body's Many Meanings

'In that hand the body is a flower; / every day the body is a fragrant flower.'

The image of a flower lends the body meanings of tenderness, scent, and touch. The ghazal presents the body as a meeting place for love, a changing floral form in relation to the mind, and a centre of social identity. The poet's creative power is evident: an onomatopoeic, scent-evoking repetition from colloquial Maithili joins the ghazal's regulated rhyme. The body is not inert matter but a site given meaning through sensation.

Many love ghazals, however, dwell on women's bodies, the ends of their garments, lips, eyes, and beauty. Their own wishes, choices, and answering voices are less fully disclosed. Verses celebrating bodily beauty cannot therefore, by themselves, prove an egalitarian conception of love. The tension between intimacy and objectification is an essential aspect of reviewing the collection.

The Vocabulary of Love and the Private Echoes of Separation

Words such as *neh*, *nor*, *mon*, *anchar*, *chan*, *ijoriya*, *kajarauta*, *phul*, and *madhumas* recur throughout the book. They activate the emotional field of the folk-song tradition. Yet the relatively autonomous couplets of the ghazal give it a different structure from the continuous narrative flow of many folk songs. Love here is less an unfolding story than a series of moments of encounter, incompletion, and sudden memory.

Sometimes meaning remains highly suggestive; elsewhere, simple address carries the poem towards song. The duality reveals two voices within the poet: one of severe satire, the other of compassionate or playful love. The best ghazals arise where these voices complement one another rather than remaining separate items in a list of topics.

Vernacular Speech, Religious Allusions, and Cultural Inversion

'The Form of the Mind Is Pasi': Revaluing Everyday Life

'The form of the mind is pasi; / the form of the body is pasi.'

Words such as *pasi*, toddy, *labni*, and *bhujja-chikhna* bring the ghazal's conventional courtly lexicon onto the ground of local social life. 'Pasi' here is not simply a word related to a drink; it becomes an autonomous term of value in the poet's metaphoric world. The juxtaposition of such popular imagery with Vedic names places humorous pressure upon the division between supposedly high and low cultures.

What social vision this reassessment develops remains an open question. Repeated use of vernacular words does not by itself provide complete representation of the communities to which they belong. The words must be considered in relation to the speaker, context, and judgements of the poem. The literary accomplishment lies in breaking an elite linguistic code and establishing ordinary experience within the language of the ghazal.

Ram and Rahman, Temple and Mosque, and the Political Use of Religion

Some ghazals explore possibilities of exchange between religious names rather than insisting upon their separation, while others mock violence and spectacle carried out in religion's name. It would therefore be misleading to reduce the poet's religious world to a single position of denial or affirmation. Condemning social hypocrisy, the poetry also suggests human coexistence. Vernacular idioms, mythic allusions, and contemporary politics broaden the thematic range of the ghazal.

The Title's Self-Reference: Humour, Violence, and the Language of the Body

'Seeing the janghajori, / even the thighs laughed aloud.'

The title returns here within the creative world of the collection itself. 'Seeing' identifies a moment of perception; 'even the thighs laughed aloud' personifies a bodily organ. Laughter becomes a mixture of humour, discomfort, and the subversion of propriety. The preceding verse contains a bloodstained image of state power. The title's play is thus not merely a bodily joke, but also suggests the strange laughter that arises beside a violent public life.

A sentence that makes a part of the body laugh is unlikely to seem natural in a purist, decorous literary idiom. Anchinhar chooses that discomfort. Yet every uncomfortable word does not amount to literary invention: the meaning here arises through its semantic collision with a context of governmental violence. This poem makes the title's potential for critical reading particularly clear.

The Texture of Language: Short Sentences, Repetition, and Explosions of Meaning

Anchinhar does not rely throughout on the Sanskritised constructions of high literary language. Colloquial words such as *kane*, *jakan*, *hunke*, *hamra*, *dunnu*, *nor*, and *mon* encounter expressions from markets and politics without hesitation. The mixture has a natural linguistic vitality. Because couplets are short, individual words acquire unusual weight: adversity against convenience, development against despondency, and miracles of religion against social violence form sharp oppositions.

At the formal level, recurring sound patterns settle in the reader's memory. Yet repetition does not necessarily add new meaning. Sometimes the glitter of alliteration hides subtleties of sense. The danger is visible in extremely brief ghazals that depend largely on phonetic similarity. A sensible test of success is whether recurrence alters meaning each time it appears.

A further problem concerns the relationship between phonetic discipline and spoken language. Maithili pronunciation allows different possibilities through sandhi, vowel length, local elongations, and regional variations. The printed metrical patterns propose a particular mode of reading; testing the changes in sound produced by oral recitation requires additional labour. Neither reducing the ghazal to a numerical calculation of written signs nor reducing it to a singer's spontaneous tune would be appropriate.

Readers' Multiple Meanings: From Declaration to Creative Practice

In the preface, the poet treats the reader as a leading participant in making meaning. The principle becomes effective in couplets such as ‘What Is Misfortune for Me’, where changing the implied speaker opens a range of social situations involving suffering and advantage. In ‘Hands Reached Out from Both Sides’, too, the refrain gains different meanings from changing situations. Not every ghazal is equally open to interpretation. A sharp political slogan, for example, makes an emphatic claim whose direction is comparatively fixed.

These differences should be understood not simply as weaknesses but as indications of the ghazal's several functions. One couplet raises a question; another acts as an immediate declaration of resistance; another preserves a memory of love. Critical criteria cannot be applied to all in the same mechanical manner. The author's theory of interpretive plurality helps explain the collection's best couplets, but turning it into a blanket certificate would conceal the specific nature of individual poems.

‘Janghajori’ in the Literary History of the Maithili Ghazal

It would be critically inadequate to describe the history of the Maithili ghazal as merely the imitation of Urdu. When a genre moves between languages, the process involves not only the copying of metres and rhymes but the formation of a new style through local syntax, social questions, traditions

of comparison, and readers' tastes. 'Janghajori' is a notable example of this cultural transformation: its claims to formal discipline connect it with inherited tradition, while its popular satire is rooted in modern Maithili life.

A historical account available in Videha proposes a line of development beginning with Pandit Jeevan Jha, followed by Kaviwar Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup', Vijaynath Jha, and Yoganand Hira. This sequence should be treated as a proposal made within Videha-associated historiography rather than an indisputable scholarly consensus. Against that background, the generation to which Anchinhar belongs is distinguished by its combined attention to renewed formal discipline, the training of poets, readers' technical participation, and publication through online media.

The poet refers in the preface to 'Anchinhar Akhar' and 'Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal'. He regards the provision of metrical patterns at the end of individual ghazals as a means of developing readers' ability to understand *bahr*. The collection thereby functions as an informal school of poetics alongside its role as a book of verse. Whereas the older tradition of Maithili lyric engaged the memory of communal singing, ragas, and folk rituals, this work addresses a new community of readers through metrical reasoning, linguistic literacy, and the printed text. The two traditions are not identical; their media and uses have changed.

Anchinhar's position in debates about the modern meeting of Maithili poetry and the ghazal cannot be measured solely through assertions of chronological priority. Historical contributions must be established through proper dating, published texts, and comparative formal examination. Anchinhar matters because he incorporates the discussion of genre into his own creative collection, bringing both the form's historical development and his poetry's aesthetics to the reader at once.

Comparative Discussion: Urdu Ghazals, Maithili Lyric Tradition, and Modern Popular Poetry

The ghazal's conventional organisation gives importance to the *matla*'s establishment of sound patterns, the relative autonomy of couplets, the recurrence of *qafiya* and *radif*, and the discipline of *bahr*. 'Janghajori' explicitly establishes its relationship to this structure. Historical Urdu examples appear in the poet's introduction, but mentioning these names does not establish direct equivalence of technique. Belonging to the same genre and possessing the same poetic temperament are different matters.

Maithili folk songs and lyrics possess a rich tradition of love, separation, seasons, comparisons involving the body, domestic courtyards, and social rituals. Anchinhar joins these images to new social circumstances. The vocabulary of body, tears, moon, and the end of a sari evokes folk-song memory, while the regulated return of the refrain and thematic leaps between couplets establish the independence of the ghazal. The collection is therefore not simply an extension of folk song, but a ghazal enriched by vernacular resources.

Compared with modern poetry of resistance, the political couplets here are short, forceful, and frequently satirical. Opposition may take the form of direct declaration or of a dramatic institutional self-confession. The concerns include difficult labour, politicians' hypocrisy, unequal benefits of development, market cruelty, and the ethical right to speak. Yet no single ideological programme exhausts the collection: the continuing presence of love, the body, and laughter makes it an exploration of broader human conduct.

The Poet's Claims to Self-Regulation and the Need for Internal Criticism

The author refuses to accord immediate prestige to the expression 'new experiment' and advocates experimenting only after learning the rules of metre. This is an educational caution. Yet the collection itself uses mythological allusions in modern contexts, self-satire spoken through media and political institutions, bodily personification, and political couplets constructed from very few words—all indications of formal experimentation in the literary sense. His refusal of 'experiment' probably means a refusal to claim invention of a new *bahr*, not an absence of all poetic innovation. Criticism must distinguish the author's statement from what the work actually does.

Likewise, printing metrical patterns with each ghazal is commendable, but the acknowledged licences at the ends of certain poems invite readers to undertake their own metrical examinations. This is not proof of artistic failure; it is an opportunity for transparency about the genre. Without adequate analysis, proclaiming every poem perfectly correct or automatically condemning all metrical licence would be equally excessive.

Limitations of the political voice are also evident. The sharpness of satire sometimes reduces characters to single traits; the complexities of public life collapse into images of thieves, cheats, or hypocrites. At times, love vocabulary returns repeatedly to the same comparison. Elsewhere, however, unexpected conjunctions of ordinary words create fresh imagery. A comprehensive judgement should therefore avoid the extremes of 'everything is excellent' and 'everything is defective'.

The Ethical Relationship Between the Ghazal Writer and the Reader

'Take a Bribe and Write a Living Ghazal about the Poor': Self-Critical Satire

> *'Take bribes, then write a living ghazal about the poor; / sit in a hotel eating chicken and eggs, and write your ghazal.'*

Here the profession of composing poetry itself becomes the subject of criticism. The speaker's instructions, taken literally, are inconsistent and ethically objectionable; readers grasp the reversed intention. The poet exposes the gap between progressive slogans and personal conduct. In the preface he

raises the question of congruence between creative assertions and behaviour; this couplet gives that thought poetic form. Its satirical target is not poverty but the literary hypocrisy that purchases prestige in the name of the poor.

The satire avoids a recurrent danger of the genre: the poet's permanent pose as a moral preacher. Repetition of the imperative 'write' allows the speaker to wear the hypocrite's mask and requires readers to reverse the apparent meaning. It is among the book's most effective self-critical strategies.

'Keep Saying Something': An Ending in Favour of Dialogue

'Keep saying something; / keep listening to something.'

The final ghazal recalls the human need for relationships through repetition of speaking and listening. After the author's long introduction and two hundred short compositions, 'something' becomes an appeal both to speak and to hear. Its broadly applicable insight is that criticism, love, and society are all incomplete without conversation. The closing beauty lies in the comparatively tender turn towards dialogue after many uncompromising political couplets.

Conclusion: A Modernity of the Maithili Ghazal Turned towards Ordinary Life

The principal literary achievement of 'Janghajori' is its combination of the ghazal's formal self-consciousness with the rough, unequal, and frequently comic-ironic experiences of Maithili everyday life. Rules of *bahr*, recurrent rhymes and refrains, short couplets, the texture of local vocabulary, and sharp observations about public institutions together establish a recognisable manner. At the collection's centre, the poet regards readers not merely as receivers of aesthetic pleasure but as participants in examining craft.

Its best couplets are those in which concise meaning, phonetic discipline, and social perspective reinforce one another. Its least successful passages are those where repetition produces no fresh meaning, accusations oversimplify complex realities, or women's independent voices remain indistinct amid descriptions of their bodies. True respect for the collection lies in making these distinctions, not in laying a uniform coat of praise over every poem.

In the history of the Maithili ghazal, Anchinhar's contribution involves his insistence on genre-conscious composition, his practice of offering technical information with the poems, and literary debate through online media. 'Janghajori' is an important poetic example of that undertaking. It demonstrates that discipline and resistance are not opposites: even within metre, poetry can raise society's most uncomfortable questions. Its ultimate significance lies in the literary evidence it offers for that possibility.

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REVIEW 9

Kumari Ichchha

Unfulfilled Desires and Completed Metre

Abstract

Ashish Anchinhar's ‘Kumari Ichchha’ is a modern Maithili ghazal collection in which metrical discipline and social discontent put each other to

the test. Across its hundred ghazals appear hunger, class division, power, markets, family fragmentation, the contradictions of modern amenities, women's labour, the writer's self-examination, and many forms of frustrated desire. The poet's extended introduction prevents the book from remaining simply a collection of poems: it advocates the development of Maithili-specific metrical patterns, discusses inherited *aruz*, and proposes new names for metres. The central argument of this study is that 'Kumari Ichchha' matters not only for these claims about prosody but also for continuously bringing them into confrontation with lived experience, vernacular language, satire, and social criticism.

Drawing on all one hundred ghazals of the original collection, the poet's statement, metrical notes printed after the poems, Videha's book catalogue, and its research archive, this study examines poetic form, conducts close readings of particular ghazals, interprets the title, and explores comparative relations with the literary history of the Maithili ghazal. Only those limited lines whose original wording was directly checked are quoted. Alongside the collection's achievements, the study identifies repetition, incompleteness in its metrical proposals, restricted independence of women's voices, and the risk of satire becoming didactic.

Keywords: Maithili ghazal; Ashish Anchinhar; Kumari Ichchha; bahr; aruz; Videha; folk melodies; satire; desire; social justice.

Literary Questions and the Approach of the Study

When evaluating a collection of poems, we naturally ask how many remain memorable, how many are rhythmically accomplished, and how intensely a poet recognises his own time. 'Kumari Ichchha' adds a further complication: if an author supplies metrical patterns and sometimes justifies licences for each ghazal, can the critic judge the emotional dimension alone, or must the formal claims be tested independently? Both tasks are necessary. Declaring a metre does not constitute accomplishment; nevertheless, experimental consciousness about prosody is itself a document of poetic history.

The study is principally centred on the book. Treating the poems as one continuous corpus, it examines their sequence, transformations of imagery, recurrence of themes, and the author's technical notes. The Videha book catalogue, research index, descriptions of Anchinhar's other available critical works, and discussions of tradition published in Videha supply useful comparative literary-historical contexts. Historical facts not independently verified against early manuscripts are treated as contexts emerging from the archive, not as newly proven discoveries.

The poet states that if readers discover within entertainment an element of knowledge, understanding, change, or improvement in life, it will be the good fortune of the poems. The statement acknowledges readers' rights. The introduction is consequently not the sole authorised meaning of the book; individual couplets may generate further significances through social circumstances, private memory, and linguistic suggestion. Criticism must

preserve this plurality while also demanding objectivity in the poet's formal claims.

The Book's Creative Sphere and the Poet's Statement

‘Kumari Ichchha’ contains one hundred consecutively numbered ghazals. A preface by the poet opens the book, and a biographical account concludes it. Most ghazals are accompanied by a specific metrical sequence, the designation of a *bahr*, or an explanation of licence. This arrangement produces an unusual two-level text: lyrical expression above, the mechanism underlying that expression below. The reader encounters hungry stomachs, breaking relationships, or political ostentation, only to be redirected immediately towards the poem's formal calculation.

In the introduction the author associates his first collection, ‘Anchinhar Akhar’, with 2011, his second, ‘Janghajori’, with 2020, and the public emergence of ‘Kumari Ichchha’ with 2021. Videha's archive also contains evidence of a later electronic circulation of the work, and these must not be treated as one publication event. The author identifies differences in the composition of all three collections, imagining a movement from simple syllabic practice to personally devised metrical sequences and then towards established Urdu and Persian metres.

His final admission is especially important. While describing the collection as metrical, he accords significance to the reader's experience in deciding whether it has sufficient feeling and rhythm. This self-examination combines poetic modesty with strategy: the poet emphasises technical labour but leaves aesthetic judgement to the reader. For a critic, this distinction matters because conformity to metre and the experience of poetry do not automatically coincide.

The Metrical Programme: Local Sound and the Encounter with a Global Poetic Form

The tension between Arabic–Persian–Urdu *aruz* and the natural pronunciation of Maithili is a longstanding intellectual question for the Maithili ghazal. Anchinhar resolves it neither through total imitation nor through unrestricted equivalence of syllable counts. He argues that line patterns should be regular, yet the phonetic qualities of Maithili may allow the development of independent *bahrs*. The language thus becomes not merely a vehicle for a borrowed form but an active force in creating its metres.

The introduction proposes for *bahr-e-Videha* a sequence of long sounds ending with a short one; *bahr-e-Govind* begins with a short sound before extending into long ones; *bahr-e-Lochan* ends in a short–long–short pattern; *bahr-e-Pradeep* revises a sequence from *khafif*; and *bahr-e-Roop* repeats the foot 2221. The names commemorate the journal Videha, Govind Jha, Ramlochan Thakur, Maithiliputra Pradeep, and Roopkant

Thakur. They are not merely metrical labels but declarations about the institutional and cultural memory of Maithili literature.

Naming a new metre and demonstrating its distinctive musical and phonetic character are, however, different undertakings. How closely do the proposed patterns correspond to forms within established *aruz*? What accepted principles should govern short and long sounds in native pronunciation? What results will an independent reader obtain from scanning the verses? These remain open questions. The author himself cautions that similarities with older metrical forms may exist. It is therefore fairer to treat the new terminology as a proposal for research and collective experiment than as a fully standardised theory.

Metrical Distribution and the Limits of Verification

A separate count of the author's notes after one hundred ghazals finds the designation *bahr-e-Mir* attached to fifty-four poems, *ramal* to nine, and *mutaqarib* explicitly to four. The remaining thirty-three are described through other patterns, individual experiments, or different metrical classes. These figures classify the author's own annotations; they are not independent certificates of correctness under traditional *aruz*. They reveal stated formal priorities without establishing the indisputable conformity of every poem.

One practical benefit of extensive use of *bahr-e-Mir* is that the poet employs a relatively regular recurrence rather than withdrawing before the tension between long and short sounds in everyday speech. Some opening couplets thus become memorable and recitable. Conversely, repeated acknowledgement of a ‘licence’ to treat two separate short sounds as a long one may weaken formal certainty. A licence sustained by indispensable musical pronunciation is one thing; a device used solely to equalise numerical counts is another.

The poet's notes, for example, give the opening ghazal on hunger the sequence 22–22–22–21; a ghazal opposing peace and revolution, 2122–2122; a ghazal concerned with the husband, 22–22–22–121; and the title-related ghazal, 222–222–222–22. Written numerical equivalence alone is insufficient: the audible rhythms of Maithili, consonant clusters and visarga, vowel weight, and the placement of pauses must all be tested. The collection is therefore a rich but debatable text for ghazal writers and researchers of metre alike.

The Couplet, Matla, Qafiya, Radif, and Independence of Meaning

The form of a ghazal is not exhausted by its metre. Establishing the same *qafiya* and *radif* in both lines of the opening *matla*, and returning to them in the prescribed positions of later couplets, creates an internal music. Recurrent words and phrases such as ‘stomach’, ‘husband’, ‘Ram Hare’, ‘difficulty’, ‘brokers of truth’, ‘taking away’, and ‘left behind’ turn the inflections of popular speech into creative resources. In many poems,

removing one couplet would still leave the others capable of making their own statements.

Yet the repeatedly returning refrain can also restrict semantic development. Repetition of ‘brokers of truth’ sharpens ridicule of powerful falsehood, but becomes mechanical if successive couplets contribute no fresh perspective. The poet's principal test lies in balancing the autonomy of the couplet against the thematic direction of the whole ghazal.

Love, family, politics, employment, and literary institutions supply further themes. The ghazal's compact structure is suited to contemporary journalistic language, short sentences, folk expressions, and sharp counter-questions. Anchinhar makes considerable use of these possibilities. Couplets in which fluid rhythm and concentrated meaning meet are more successful than those that remain slogans or simple statements of fact.

Language, Folk Speech, and Intertextuality

Instead of relying on formal erudition, the collection often draws vitality from village and domestic conversation. Words such as *mon* (‘mind’), *pet* (‘stomach’), *angan* (‘courtyard’), *bhatar* (‘husband’), *sasur* (‘marital home’), *naihar* (‘parental home’), *paikar* (‘merchant’), *darbar* (‘court’), *kapar* (‘forehead’), and *junna* place poetic subjects in everyday life. Alongside them appear ‘system’, ‘reporting’, ‘file’, ‘free’, ‘geyser’, and ‘office’, opening the objects and institutions of contemporary society. Such a mixed vocabulary should not be automatically condemned as linguistic impurity: it registers the interpenetration of market, administration, and home.

Folk melodies, devotional refrains, memories of Kabir, and satirical impersonation deepen the work's intertextual relations. The author explicitly states that the phrase ‘Ram Hare’ in one ghazal has been borrowed from a devotional song. In politically themed ghazals using folk melodies, the sound structure readily suggests public gatherings or group performance. The ghazal thereby moves beyond private exchanges between lovers towards a social oral culture.

The immediacy of words such as ‘face’, ‘dress’, ‘game’, and ‘system’ nevertheless makes the poems historically situated. If foreign words introduced for metrical equivalence do not fit naturally into the internal rhythm, oral tension may result. This criticism is not linguistic purism; it asks whether every word is poetically necessary in sound and context.

Individual Close Readings

Hunger as Metaphor: From an Empty Stomach to the State's Immorality

‘The empty stomach remained offended; / the stomach simply would not agree.’

The collection's first ghazal brings the reader not into the world of private romance but before the demands of hunger. Being ‘offended’ is a human

emotional act, but the poet attributes it to the stomach. This personification gives the hungry body a voice of entitlement. The absence of food also tests the morality of religious acts; references to holy men and government turn the satire towards hunger as a material problem. The refrain 'stomach' becomes both the rhythm of humour and the persistence of deprivation.

This opening establishes the collection's thematic principle: moral peace has an incomplete meaning without material security. Although the poet does not formulate a policy to overcome hunger, his brief couplets set lofty ideals against the empty stomach. Each return of the refrain obliges readers to confront the same problem again.

Peace of the Mind versus Revolution of the Stomach

'The mind became a pacifist; / the stomach became a revolutionary.'

The opening couplet transforms the commonplace opposition between peace and revolution into a dynamic relation between body and consciousness. The mind is inclined to compromise with ideals, while the stomach pushes towards disagreement under the pressure of livelihood. This materialist miniature of social revolution arises from simple experience instead of intricate theoretical argument. Subsequent images of kings, queens, masters, and servants interpret the social hierarchy.

The couplet is powerful because of its aphoristic sharpness. Yet collecting many such aphorisms risks reducing complicated social processes to straightforward binaries. The poet succeeds in making the theme incisive; weakness arises when new names for familiar oppositions replace particular details of experience.

External Unity and Internal Disintegration: The Husband Sequence

'Outwardly, the husband is held together; / inwardly, the husband is broken.'

The central word *bhatar* identifies the husband's role within a relationship, while joining it to 'joined' and 'broken' opens a distance between external appearance and internal disintegration. Language becomes a criticism of fixed family roles. A relationship that seems united from outside is fractured within: a compressed image of social display and emotional displacement. Hints of the mirage of development, calculation, desire, and wounds inflicted by one's own people give the fragility an economic and social background.

The metrical note is especially significant because the poet offers this poem as an example of his proposed *bahr-e-Lochan*. It is therefore both an account of contradictions within marriage and a laboratory for a language-specific metre. Its literary examination should attend to the effect of the final short–long–short pattern in relation to the audible force of the *bhatar* refrain.

Religious Sound and Administrative Reality

'Every facility is governmental, Ram Hare; / all authority belongs to them alone, Ram Hare.'

Repetition of 'Ram Hare' evokes the collective tone of a devotional hymn, but the themes move in the opposite direction. The inclusion of public facilities, governmental domination, reporting, mutual aggression, and personal anxiety alongside devotional words introduces a satire of worldly corruption into sacred sound. Its beauty lies in contrast: the more familiar and easy the devotional cadence, the harsher the social reproach.

This ghazal is a key example for understanding relations between folk song and the ghazal. The devotional phrase need not signal unbroken religious surrender; its repetition may expose the emptiness of social rituals. Yet if each couplet fails to introduce a fresh contradiction, 'Ram Hare' itself may become formulaic. The possibility demands evaluation of the difference between oral popularity and literary depth.

Brokers of Truth: The Satirical Work of the Radif

'The broker of truth roars loudly; / the broker of truth laughs uproariously.'

In this opening couplet, truth is not an unconditionally sacred value but a commodity for trade. 'Broker' signals the inversion of social morality. Roaring, laughing, glittering, constantly changing, and selling oneself—the series strips the mask from those who claim to represent truth. Brief sounds, blows of mockery, and recurring words together produce the effect of a political and cultural masquerade.

The formal distinction is that the poet does not write a direct argumentative essay of accusation and evidence. He sketches character through a sequence of gestures. Excessive reliance on a strongly judgemental word such as 'broker', however, may reduce the variety of imagery. The most effective couplet reveals a new pattern of behaviour rather than simply hurling abuse.

The Image of Green Spectacles and a Daughter's Double Burden

'For a daughter there are twice the sorrows; / look at the marital home, look at the parental home.'

The lines describe a woman's social position through the two centres of her marital home and parental home. Questions about her right to a home, the expectations placed on her, labour, and humiliation are immediately raised. 'Twice the sorrows' allows an interpretation of the burdens imposed by two families. The poem is not an intimate autobiography in a woman's own voice, but it questions inequality within patriarchal relations.

In the opening couplet, 'green spectacles' become a satirical symbol of the act of seeing. By contrast, the verse on the daughter demands the removal of a distorted mental lens. Satire here is not directed solely outward; it becomes a form of social self-examination. The critic must remember that making

women a subject and allowing women to speak independently are not identical acts.

The Meaning of the Title: Rice Water, Salt, Vermilion, and Maidenly Desire

'The rich have problems of diamonds and gold; / the poor have problems of rice water and salt.'

'How could vermilion fulfil every desire? / If some desires remain maidenly, what is the difficulty?'

These two couplets disclose the philosophical centre of the book's title. The rich worry about 'diamonds and gold', while the poor are concerned with rice water and salt. The first couplet uses the same word, 'difficulty', to expose the incomparability of problems across classes. Both are called difficulties, yet their value for life differs radically. This opposition is among the clearest images of the poet's social consciousness. The minimal requirements for food and the desires of luxury are confronted within a single structure of rhyme and refrain.

The words 'vermilion' and 'maidenly' in the second couplet introduce different layers of meaning. One is a social marker of married status, while the other becomes an image of unfinished longing. The poet does not regard the fulfilment of every wish as necessary; allowing some desires to remain 'unmarried' may express both human incompleteness and a form of self-protection. The title is not simply a designation of a woman's marital condition but also a metaphor for a zone of aspiration that escapes possession.

Nevertheless, reading 'maidenly' merely as an aesthetic condition of untouched purity would be restrictive. The presence of vermilion raises questions about the institution of marriage and women's social recognition. As hunger, poverty, the marital and parental homes, and the suffering of brides recur through the collection, the title's image becomes socially charged. Personal incompletion and structural inequality illuminate rather than cancel one another.

Political Ghazals in Folk Melodies and the Testimony of Rivers

'There are tears on the banks of Kosi, Kamala, and Ganga; / vermilion and ritual rice paste are mingled with tears.'

In a folk-melody ghazal depicting political leaders and distressed people, the Kosi, Kamala, and Ganga cease to be merely geographical names. Linked to regional loss, displacement, communal life, and the auspicious symbols of women—vermilion and rice paste—they become symbols of sorrow. The separation between tears and river water appears to vanish. Lyrical repetition transforms individual suffering into a collective lament.

The ghazal's power lies in its sound. Folk melody creates listeners as well as readers. The actual political and environmental histories of the rivers, however, cannot be contained in a few lines; readers must bring some knowledge of local social contexts to the poem. The poet is not writing history but creating poetic signs of historical pain.

Agricultural Production, Traders, and the Economy of Awards

'The trader takes away the harvest of the field; / what remains is taken away by the overlord.'

'The body's radiance vanished into the fire of hunger; / prizes take away the sharp edge of the pen.'

The first couplet exposes the distance between agricultural labour and control of its products. The crop belongs to the field, the profits to the trader, and the remainder is appropriated by the powerful. The criticism of relations of production becomes a metrical condensation, not simply an economic statement. The second couplet juxtaposes the body's loss of vitality with the loss of the pen's edge to prizes, criticising possible distortions within literary institutions. The 'fire of hunger' and 'awards' join economic inequality with cultural inequality in one poem.

The couplet also carries a risk: if the reference to prizes becomes a universal allegation, the distinctions among complex literary institutions may disappear. Nevertheless, it raises a question that deserves attention: how does the distribution of literary prestige relate to creative labour and social need? The poet keeps this question alive as a source of discomfort for readers.

The Geyser, the Peepal Tree, and the Bride: The Double Truth of Development

'They cut down the peepal tree; / they installed a geyser in the courtyard.'

'The bride cries out in hunger; / outside, a celebratory birth song rises.'

The replacement of a peepal tree with a geyser brings modern consumption into contact with environmental loss. A living tree bearing communal and cultural significance gives way to an instrument of private convenience; 'development' is therefore not automatically synonymous with progress. The satire grows from the unexpected juxtaposition of peepal and geyser. Rather than simply reading this as condemnation of mechanical modernity, it is more productive to ask the price of convenience and who benefits from it.

The opposition between the hungry bride and the *sohar*, a festive birth song sounding outside, reveals the terrible separation of public celebration and domestic insecurity. Collective noise conceals the suffering of a woman's body. The folk-song-like particle 'ho' makes the satire singable, while the couplet's ethical energy comes from a private wound. The collection can thereby bring questions of women, food, family, and nature together within one brief ghazal.

The Final Couplets: Civilisation, Violence, and the Absence of People

'A world survives without its people; / what survives are only avatars.'

'Outwardly we became civilised; / inwardly the savage remained alive.'

The closing ghazal begins by questioning the absence of 'the people'. That the world survives is not the same as saying that its people are truly present—a compressed insight into social and political life. Images of the coexistence of

government and crime, the pervasive reach of the court, and the uselessness of votes carry the poem beyond electoral procedures towards a crisis of ethical existence.

The last couplet opposes the outward appearance of civilisation to the survival of violence within. The collection has travelled from the empty stomach of its opening poem to the hollowness of social institutions. The ‘maidenly desire’ of its title is no longer simply incomplete romantic longing: it becomes the aspiration to make people fully human, continually frustrated by existing social arrangements.

The Ghazal Writer's Self-Identification and the Poetics of Irony

‘Anchinhar’ appears in many ghazals as a *takhallus* or recurring word. The poet places himself among people whose conduct becomes self-serving after public speeches, who hear contrary voices within themselves, and who experience incomplete recognition. This self-doubt prevents the satire from becoming wholly external accusation. Attacking the public morality of Mithila, the poet also places his own authorial identity under scrutiny.

At the level of technique, such self-mockery is one of the collection's strengths. In a conventional *maqta*, the *takhallus* can convey self-esteem; here it sometimes signifies failure, uncertainty, or self-directed humour. A dialogue is perceptible between the oral tradition of Mithila's joking wit and a modern critical personality.

The repetition of self-doubt may nonetheless become a fixed pose. When a poet repeatedly describes himself as troubled, readers are entitled to ask where self-examination becomes a distinct personal experience and where it remains a general assertion. Maintaining this distinction is necessary for impartial criticism.

The Maithili Ghazal: A Comparative View of Tradition and Change

The introduction to ‘Representative Maithili Ghazals’ available in Videha provides a basis for examining the form's history from the early twentieth century to the present. This archival account places Pandit Jeevan Jha among the earliest documented names, while discussing Kaviwar Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra ‘Madhup’, Jagdishchandra Thakur ‘Anil’, Yoganand Hira, and other writers. The sequence should not be regarded as a simple triumphal story of linear progress. Different periods may have developed distinctive relations among the ghazal, lyric, song, couplet, rhythm, and metrical consciousness.

The early question concerned the adoption of Arabic and Persian metres and their fit with Maithili pronunciation. In later periods, debates about formal correctness versus broad comprehensibility, songlike lines versus autonomous couplets, and creative freedom versus metrical rules become more explicit. Videha's electronic literary public sphere extended these debates through articles, responses, publication of ghazals, and discussions of prosody.

Anchinhar's 'Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal', 'Sandarbh Sahit', and related writings are archival traces of this conversation.

The poet's own declared journey from 'Anchinhar Akhar' through 'Janghajori' to 'Kumari Ichchha' offers an interesting account of formal change. He describes the first as practice in simple syllabic forms, the second as experimentation with personally selected patterns, and the third as a combination of established and proposed metres. This self-description should be treated as evidence of the tendencies within his writing, not accepted without qualification as literary history. The actual achievement of 'Kumari Ichchha' is that arguments about metre remain connected to the living language of hunger, voting, villages, women, rivers, and family.

Entries in Videha's research archive for Anchinhar's 'Qafiya', 'Qafiya and Bahr', 'Early Experiments in Maithili Ghazal Grammar', 'The Maithili Ghazal in the Context of Expression', and 'A Comparative Study of Narendraji's Maithili and Hindi Ghazals' show that formal problems of the ghazal remained central to his criticism. Their listing alone cannot establish the correctness of all his conclusions, but it places the introduction to 'Kumari Ichchha' within a sustained critical inquiry.

The Differences Among Folk Melodies, Free Verse, and the Ghazal

The contradiction between song and ghazal is often explained by simple generic distinctions, but Maithili's various oral traditions do not permit such rigid separations. A composition based upon a folk melody does not thereby lose the possibility of being a ghazal if its *matla*, *qafiya*, *radif*, relations among couplets, and declared *bahr* remain consistent with the form's requirements. 'Ram Hare' and the politically themed folk-melody ghazals offer illuminating examples.

Anchinhar's writing also demonstrates that the subject of satire does not alone determine a poetic genre. Hunger, unemployment, and opposition to authority can be treated in the *doha*, song, independent lyric, or ghazal. The distinction depends upon structure and the oral construction of meaning, not subject matter. Hence a refrain or lines of similar length are not sufficient criteria: the phonetic operation of the rhyme, consistency of *bahr*, and relative independence of couplets require joint examination.

Insistence on the integrity of the genre is useful when it gives new experiments room to develop. If rules become merely instruments of exclusion, literary development is impeded. The collection's internal tension is that the poet demands strict traditional *aruz* while proposing new Maithili metres. These apparently contradictory commitments offer a creative opportunity: tradition supplies a standard, while the language reorganises it.

Concision, Repetition, and Poetic Risk

In the poet's strongest works, a material object opens onto a larger ethical crisis: the stomach, rice water and salt, a peepal tree, a geyser, a trader, or

vermilion. Such concrete vocabulary creates scenes where abstract instruction would otherwise stand. Especially memorable are the contrast between rich and poor people's different ‘difficulties’, the clash between the hungry bride and a birth celebration, and the appropriation of the field's harvest.

Less effective passages are those in which repeated generalisations pronounce conclusions without encountering adequate resistance. Claims about government corruption, political deceit, social hypocrisy, or the fragmentation of friendship may be true to experience; nevertheless, poetry deepens when unexpected incidents, images, or human contradictions replace general statements. The collection contains successful instances of such imagery, but not all ghazals achieve the same concentration.

The historical usefulness of the metrical notes printed at the ends of poems is beyond doubt. Yet readers seeking an uninterrupted poetic experience may find that technical commentary immediately after a composition interrupts its musical absorption. Future editions could separate the poems from a prosodic appendix, allowing both purposes to be realised more clearly. This criticism does not diminish the original edition's value; it distinguishes its educational and aesthetic uses.

Achievements and Limitations in the Representation of Gender

Words such as ‘bride’, ‘daughter’, ‘marital home’, ‘parental home’, and ‘vermilion’ make inequalities in women's lives visible. The difference between hunger and celebration raises a pointed question about women's invisible labour. The relation of ‘Kumari Ichchha’ to marriage conventions brings women not simply into view as objects of male desire but into a complex field of social customs and unfulfilled longing.

Nonetheless, most ghazals are voiced by an external observer. Women are seldom permitted extended arguments in their own idiom. This cannot be counted as a defect of every poem, since the collection pursues a broad project of social satire; but the feminine form of the title makes the autonomy of women's speech a legitimate subject of inquiry. Compassion expressed on behalf of women's experience is not identical to a woman's self-determining voice. This distinction produces a fairer evaluation.

The Collection's Place in Literary History

‘Kumari Ichchha’ invites a double reading: as a manifesto for new experiments in metre within the Maithili ghazal and as a brief archive of social criticism. In his introduction, the poet insists on disciplined craft; in the poems, he tests the power of popular speech, satire, and poetic concision. Consequently, the volume becomes not only an account of private emotion but a poetic testimony to the contradictions of public life.

Its importance in Maithili literary history cannot be established by untested descriptions such as ‘first’ or ‘greatest’. Its significance lies in a specific conjunction: a hundred ghazals in one volume, extensive formal discussion,

proposed names for metres, folk-melody adaptations, self-satire, class criticism, and acknowledgement of the reader's decisive part in meaning. These qualities make the book worthy of study; independent verification of its claims concerning metre remains a task for further research.

Conclusion

The most fruitful reading of ‘Kumari Ichchha’ recognises that poetry is neither merely the triumph of metre nor merely a social slogan. The poet's technical labour gives rhythm to rough experience; actual hunger, broken relationships, women's suffering, political theatre, and market inequality give meaning to that rhythm. Powerful beauty arises when form and experience depend upon each other.

The ‘maidenly’ quality of the title accepts that some wishes remain unfulfilled while resisting the social arrangements that leave people's fundamental rights unsatisfied. The contrast between the rich and poor people's different ‘difficulties’ raises the title to the level of social philosophy. Read beside the final ghazal's image of a world without its people, the collection asks not only ‘why is desire unfulfilled?’ but also ‘who controls the social conditions of its fulfilment?’

The volume's achievements lie in confident musicality, incisive vernacular speech, technical self-awareness, and concise articulation of social problems. Its limitations are uneven poetic quality, repetitive satire, uncertainties surrounding metrical licence, and the comparatively small space given to autonomous female voices. Considered together, these strengths and weaknesses establish ‘Kumari Ichchha’ as a creatively significant, research-worthy, and debate-provoking collection of modern Maithili ghazals.

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PART III

Ghazal Poetics: Grammar, Debate, and Criticism

Rereading Maithili Literature

REVIEW 10

A Ready Reckoner for the Maithili Ghazal

At the Confluence of Metre, Language, and Creation

Book under review: Ashish Anchinhar

Abstract

Ashish Anchinhar's A Ready Reckoner for the Maithili Ghazal is a concise, practice-oriented guide to the metrical system of the Maithili ghazal: bahr, rukn, qafiya, radif, case endings, pronunciation, and creative revision. This study examines the introduction and internal organisation of all five parts of the book, comparing its significance for the genre with modern Maithili ghazal criticism, Videha's literary initiatives, and Arabic–Persian–Urdu ghazal poetics. Particular attention is given to the distinctive decisions Anchinhar advances, while adopting traditional technical terminology, concerning Maithili's attachment of case suffixes, the pronunciation of short and long syllables, the chandrabindu, reph, consonant clusters, and the local use of the takhallus. The study concludes that the book's major achievements lie in its

accessible presentation of rules, example-based exercises, and openness to revising its own earlier decisions. Nevertheless, the relation between speech sounds and script, the obligatory status of metrical rules, the evaluation of the musalsal ghazal, and the universal validity of certain prohibitions concerning qafiya call for reconsideration. The book is not merely an aid to beginners; it constitutes an important attempt to develop a specialised critical vocabulary for Maithili.

Keywords: Maithili ghazal; Ashish Anchinhar; bahr; rukn; qafiya; radif; case endings; phonetics; prosody; literary history; Videha.

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Introduction: The Larger Questions Raised by a Concise Book

It is easy to regard a ghazal as no more than a succession of emotionally charged couplets; understanding its technical organisation is considerably harder. The autonomy of the sher, the recurrence of qafiya and radif, the regularity of bahr, and the rhythms of language distinguish the ghazal from other lyric forms. Its adoption in Maithili raises two related questions: how can the essential framework of traditional ghazal poetics be preserved, and how can Maithili's own phonological, morphological, and syntactic character find expression within that framework? Ashish Anchinhar's A Ready Reckoner for the Maithili Ghazal stands between these questions and offers a systematic programme of introductory training in the form.

The English expression “Ready Reckoner” in the title is significant. The book does not claim to provide a comprehensive aesthetics of the ghazal; rather, it seeks to put usable rules, concise explanations, and examples within immediate reach. In his introduction the author acknowledges that condensation may reduce the scope for elaborating concepts, while leaving the need for extended study intact. Whether this awareness of the book's limits should be read as a weakness or as generic honesty is the first critical question. In my view, its value becomes clearer when it is treated as a workshop companion rather than a final, authoritative reference work. [1]

This study maintains a clear distinction between the book's propositions and the reviewer's critical judgements. Wherever the author formulates a rule, the strength of its examples and reasoning must be tested; it would be inappropriate to assume that a convention current in one tradition is necessarily binding on every language and every period. Equally, practical simplifications devised to help the novice ghazal writer cannot uncritically be treated as substitutes for full-fledged linguistic theory.

Objectives and Critical Approach

This research essay pursues four objectives. First, it offers separate close readings of the technical material organised across the five parts of the book. Second, it tests the reasoning behind proposals concerning short and long syllables, letters and morae, pronunciation and script, case endings and qafiya, and the relation between feeling and form. Third, it locates the work comparatively within the historical development of the Maithili ghazal and the contemporary critical environment fostered through Videha. Fourth, it assesses the book's utility and limitations in relation to training, the revision of compositions, and criticism.

Methodologically, this is a work-centred critical study. Its primary source is the book itself. Videha's book lists, research lists, and comparative essays on the ghazal

available there supply the literary context. Comparison with Arabic–Persian–Urdu ghazal traditions operates at the conceptual level: no exhaustive survey of those traditions is claimed here. Greater weight is assigned to critical testing of the explicitly available prosodic propositions and exercises than to historical claims drawn from external sources. [1][2][3][4]

The Book's Character, Organisation, and Self-Presentation

The original book comprises its title, dedication, an author's statement entitled “Anchinhar's Words,” five parts, and an author biography. Its arrangement follows the progression of a training manual rather than the linear history of a conventional research monograph. Part One introduces basic prosody; Part Two the components of the ghazal and qafiya; Part Three Maithili case endings and vowel correspondences; Part Four consonant clusters, short vowels, reph, and the defect called ita; and Part Five stress, the maqta, revision of composition, and an introduction to bahr-e-Mir. The pedagogical principle governing this order is “first the tools of language and metre, then composition.” [1]

The author approaches the ghazal through both technical and emotional dimensions, but reserves this concise volume for technical instruction. This does not mean that the neglect of emotion is desirable; in fact, the opening discussion affirms the necessity of both. The book's identity is thus founded on a distinction of levels rather than a contradiction: the practice of rules in one volume, the fuller exploration of feeling and literary history in a larger work. The reference to A Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal indicates that distinction; Videha's book catalogue records the latter as a separate publication. [1][2]

A notable quality of the preface is its self-criticism. The author reports having corrected certain errors in his earlier exposition. In a rule-governed form such as the ghazal, this admission is an essential feature of a critical culture: standards are formed by reasoned correction, not by immutable prohibitions. It permits the author to be understood not as the ultimate arbiter but as a participant in the process of evidence and verification. At some points, however, the book also employs the language of absolute certainty. This duality will be relevant in the discussions that follow.

Part One: An Introduction to Short and Long Syllables, Bahr, and Rukn

The first part establishes the technical foundations of ghazal poetics. The author defines bahr in terms of following an identical sequence of metrical quantities in the lines of a ghazal. The distinction between equality of the total number of morae and equality of their arrangement is crucial. Two lines may have the same total, yet differences in the order of short and long syllables can alter their weight and rhythm. Hence the book adopts the notation 1 and 2 and provides exercises in combining rukns. This numerical language offers beginners an entry point, particularly when traditional names are unfamiliar. [1]

The account of rukn introduces five-unit and four-unit patterns, the names fa'ulun, fa'ilun, fa'ilatun, mafa'ilun, mustaf'ilun, among others, and lists their successive metrical weights. The author shows how mathematical sequences can help memorise the rukns. This instructional construction is noteworthy because it converts difficult phonetic names into memorable patterns of short and long syllables. For students of verse composition, it connects formula with practice. Memorising a formula,

however, is not the same as possessing rhythmic sensitivity; listening, pronunciation, and singability remain indispensable checks.

The author considers the weight of a syllable preceding a consonant cluster, the difference between anusvara and chandrabindu, visarga, and possible changes in metrical sequence across word boundaries. Examples such as “ghar,” “bigari,” “bhinsar,” and “kabkab” illustrate the relation between a word's internal stresses and its metrical quantities. Pronunciation may shift when case endings or groups of words are joined: this observation moves beyond exclusively written prescriptions towards actual speech. Such attention is particularly valuable in a language as richly varied in conversational usage as Maithili.

Here the first important critical issue emerges. In certain contexts the author brings the traditional length of a written character, its pronounced duration, and its accentual stress into a single process of counting. That is convenient for practical instruction, but in modern phonetics the written character, vowel duration, stress, and metrical weight occupy different analytical levels. An account of pronunciation is essential to understanding a word's use in metre, but greater care is needed to accommodate the variety of native pronunciations. The compressed nature of the manual limits the scope of such analysis.

Especially deserving attention in Part One is the exercise called “sauti mushaira.” The author temporarily sets meaning aside to practise the metre, qafiya, and radif. Just as the early training of a musician may involve practising notes independently of verbal meaning, preliminary structural exercises can teach the ghazal writer rhythmic discipline. But if that means is elevated into a final literary ideal, the relation between sound and meaning in the sher will be weakened. The author himself assigns meaninglessness only a limited role within the exercise; this limitation must be kept firmly in view by the critic.

In classifying bahr, the author introduces the traditional terminology for original, composite, and altered metres, while also adopting convenient labels such as “equal,” “half-equal,” and “unequal.” These designations represent not merely translation but a reorganisation of teaching. Their utility is apparent when beginners attempt to grasp the relationships among traditional rukns. Yet comprehensive evidence is not supplied for the sources of the conventional enumerations, the legitimacy of altered patterns, or disagreements among schools of prosody. The list is therefore more dependable as an introductory guide than as a final scholarly enumeration.

Part Two: The Grammar of Sher, Matla, Radif, and Qafiya

The second part leads the reader from the ghazal's external identity towards its internal composition. The author stresses the thematic autonomy of the two-line sher, prescribes the presence of qafiya and radif in both lines of the matla and their recurrence in the second lines of subsequent couplets. Terms including musalsal and non-musalsal ghazal, husn-e-matla, ghair-muraddaf ghazal, tahlili radif, and taqabul-e-radif are explained through examples. A major merit of the section is that its terminology never remains an isolated glossary: every term is connected to actual compositional practice. [1]

Qafiya receives particularly extended attention. The author examines not merely similar sounds or metrical quantities, but the final character of rhyming words, the preceding vowel, and the sequence of correspondences. Words such as “rag–tag–bhag” demonstrate that qafiya is not simply a matter of visibly matching final

letters, but a rule of recurrent sound structure. Readers are instructed to work backwards from the ends of words to identify the correspondence. That procedure teaches them to recognise the subtle formal patterns underlying the rhyme.

In discussing radif, the allowance for identical wording with divergent meanings is a creative insight. Repetition of a word need not require the same meaning on every occasion; variation may increase a couplet's polysemic possibilities. Formal recurrence in the ghazal can thus become an instrument of semantic expansion rather than stagnation. Through the anticipation of qafiya and the return of radif, the reader develops expectations which the sher either fulfils or unsettles to achieve its effect. The book does not dwell extensively on this aesthetic process, but its examples make the possibility apparent.

Conversely, the author's tendency to accord the musalsal ghazal comparatively less recognition illustrates a generic value judgement. The autonomy of the sher is unquestionably one of the ghazal's defining strengths; thematic continuity, however, need not diminish poetic quality. A common subject may sustain contrasting perspectives, the gradual development of meanings, and recurring symbols. It is therefore appropriate to recognise musalsal and non-musalsal as different types, but not to make the distinction the sole criterion of literary worth. This critical difference creates a dialogue between the book's prescriptive dimension and the aesthetic experience of the modern reader.

The instructions concerning the minimum number of couplets in a ghazal must likewise be situated between conventional teaching norms and historical variety. The dimensions of traditional ghazals have varied across periods, linguistic environments, and editorial traditions. The guidance offered here may be useful for elementary practice; it is insufficient, however, to treat it as the genre's single, timeless boundary. The author's purpose is to maintain formal discipline, whereas history sometimes presents exceptions.

Part Three: Case Endings, Vowel Correspondence, and the Question of Maithilisation

The third part represents one of the book's most important local interventions. In Maithili, the written attachment of case endings, the inflection of nouns, and conventions of pronunciation create both difficulties and opportunities when determining the qafiya of a ghazal. The author examines the addition of the same case suffix to different stems, such as “kalamsā” and “patansā,” before asking whether the common inflection belongs to qafiya or radif. This is not merely an orthographic issue; it concerns the interrelation of metre, sound, and grammar. [1]

In this section, testing the correspondence of the remaining root words after removing case endings emerges as a practical criterion. If a phonetic correspondence remains intact after the suffixes are removed, interpreting the common ending as radif becomes possible; if the stems do not correspond, the judgement changes. The rule matters critically because it does not subject the living grammar of Maithili to passive imitation of Arabic–Urdu ghazal poetics; rather, it demands a legitimate place for Maithili linguistic forms within the genre.

Examples of case endings occurring within the line are especially revealing of the subtle process of Maithilisation. In the author's analysis, word boundaries and the boundaries of radif do not invariably coincide. Structures such as “hamra sangme aam chhai” and “hamra hathme aam chhai” require the relation between qafiya and radif within an inflected expression to be interpreted differently. Far from being

mere technical anomalies, these examples document the internal pressure exerted by Maithili syntax. The structure of the local language itself intervenes in the interpretation of an inherited form.

The author himself raises the possibility that such allowances could be abused. This self-awareness is important: if rules are expanded without testing, the assessment of qafiya correspondence and the identification of radif may become arbitrary. A stronger critical method would place counterexamples, variations of pronunciation, and evidence from regional dialects beside the proposed exceptions. Otherwise a sensible teaching accommodation may harden into an allegedly universal prescription.

In the discussion of vowel-based qafiya, examples are given of the vowels i, a, u, e, ai, o, and au in their long forms. By examining the relation between spoken vowels and their written vowel signs, the author distinguishes several degrees of correspondence between sounds and clusters of letters. The fundamental question here is how far qafiya should depend on hearing, and how far on graphic similarity. When the author insists upon preserving identical spelling, a written prescriptiveness becomes attached to a framework otherwise grounded in phonetic similarity.

Another major critical feature of this part is the author's revision of his own compositions. The qafiyas in previously published ghazals are retested against a later criterion, and some earlier usages are judged inconsistent. Such a declaration has particular significance in the history of poetics. Rather than inventing exceptions to protect one's own literary reputation when formulating a rule, the application of a new principle to one's earlier poems signals critical responsibility. Yet the aesthetic grounds for the new rule must also be examined independently: self-correction is not, in itself, conclusive proof of a theory's truth.

Part Four: Pronunciation, Reph, Consonant Clusters, and the Defect of Ita

The fourth part is rich in linguistic detail. Consonant clusters; the treatment of short i and u; chandrabindu; the difference between words with reph and a full r; sound distinctions such as s–sh–sh and n–retroflex n; and the examination of the ita defect all link the technical study of ghazals directly with questions of Maithili linguistics. The author offers instances in which the written and pronounced forms of the same word differ. Here the ghazal ceases to be merely an imported form: its rules begin to enter into dialogue with the local phonology of Maithili. [1]

In relation to short i and u, the author emphasises orthographic discipline in qafiya. Showing variations in the pronunciation of words such as “mati,” he links the rhyming pattern to the presence of written i. The significance of such observations is that spoken Maithili is neither static nor uniform; a single spelling can admit several pronunciations. Yet when the author absolutely prohibits a form different from a specified qafiya, dialectal variation, popular usage, and actual phonetic correspondence demand independent examination.

The examples involving reph and a complete r are especially pertinent. Maithili frequently displays a difference between reph-bearing forms associated with Sanskrit and sounds common in everyday speech. The author tests the confrontation between written tradition and living pronunciation against the criterion of qafiya. The work's strength here lies in its selection of examples; its limitation is the occasional elevation of an imagined standard pronunciation above dialectal diversity. The value

of a literary language lies in negotiating this tension, not in the universal triumph of either alternative.

The explanation of the ita defect is a distinctive methodological achievement of Part Four. The author compares the bases of words formed with vowel signs, suffixes, prefixes, or sandhi. When qafiya appears to correspond on the surface but the semantic relation between stems and their rhyme structure fails to satisfy specified conditions, the question of ita arises. With examples such as "bimari–harami" and "dosti–dushmani," he exposes the layers of word formation. Grammar, etymology, and sound are brought together in a single analysis.

Nevertheless, the process of retrieving the root of a word when applying the ita rule may itself be disputed. Because of productive suffixation, historical borrowings, semantic innovation, and changes in spoken forms, it is not always possible to divide every word neatly into a stem and a suffix. A word's present meaning may differ from its historical origin. Consequently, the superficial phonetic correspondence of qafiya, the history of word formation, and the reader's experience of meaning should be tested separately. This caution preserves the usefulness of the author's proposition while reducing unnecessary prohibitions.

Viewed as a whole, Part Four asks a central question: how will the Maithili ghazal acquire its own linguistic identity? The author's answer is not unilinear. Rigorous adherence to traditional aruz in some contexts, allowances relative to Maithili pronunciation in others, and certainty based on written forms elsewhere coexist. This may not be a contradiction, but it is certainly an active intellectual tension. It should become an object of criticism, since the development of a locally grounded ghazal poetics is possible through precisely such struggles.

Part Five: Stress, Maqta, and the Creative Discipline of Revision

The fifth part returns to the basic consideration of morae in the first, now approaching it through accentual stress. Demonstrating alternative pronunciations of "ghar," "kamal," and "bhinsar," the author urges that metrical decisions be taken in relation to meaning. An important principle emerges: analysing metrical quantities cannot be entirely independent of semantics. Some sound patterns generate different meanings; a ghazal writer must therefore preserve meaning while fulfilling the bahr. In this way the earlier injunction to learn technique first assumes a more sophisticated form.

In introducing the maqta, the author discusses the position of the takhallus and grammatical inflections of a name. In Maithili, case endings can be attached to personal names. This inflection does not invalidate the maqta; it establishes a local grammar for the poet's self-presence in the concluding couplet. The author demands consistency in the use of names and pen names, and argues that enclosing a name in quotation marks may restrict its semantic potential. Poetic identity, grammar, and the plurality of meanings converge in this fine-grained discussion.

The culminating example in the fifth part is a study of the revision of a ghazal by Jagdish Chandra Thakur "Anil." The different metrical sequences in the original lines are examined, and revisions proposed to bring them into a common pattern. The two lines of the revised matla read:

I am broken; that is why I recite ghazals.

I am hungry; that is why I recite ghazals.

Through their repeated phrasing, these lines connect personal brokenness and hunger to the impulse to speak through the ghazal. "Broken" suggests bodily or psychological fragmentation, while "hungry" evokes the material deprivations of life. The common radif does not merely repeat a feeling in a straight line; it binds two different causes of experience into a shared verbal rhythm. [1]

Throughout the revision exercise, the words of the original idea are rearranged. This is useful for teaching craft, but its literary consequences are mixed. Some situations in the original draft change; the relationship between the new lines and the original theme also shifts. If preserving the bahr weakens the spontaneity of experience or the movement of meaning, the revision cannot be called an unqualified success. The reader must apply two standards together: metrical consistency and the artistic unity of the sher. A technically flawless couplet is not necessarily a compelling one; and adjusting a compelling theme to the demands of the form requires a distinct kind of creative labour.

The author closes by introducing bahr-e-Mir and noting its convenience for new ghazal writers. Relatively flexible acceptance of metrical weights, possible combinations of the pronunciations of separate words, and the conception of new metres for Maithili are significant here. This is not simply an exercise in imitation but a proposal for creative local expansion of the genre. His warning that allowances should be distinguished from regular practice is nonetheless meaningful: beginners ought first to understand basic structure, lest they mistake exceptions for ordinary rules.

Close Reading of the Quotations: The Union of Technique and Experience

In his opening statement, the author treats the two dimensions of a ghazal—the technical or prosodic and the emotional—as equally necessary. This proposition counters the common tendency to understand the ghazal merely as a means of "filling the required metrical weight." The creative imperative is that bahr should become a vehicle of natural expression, not feel like an external constraint imposed on the reader. When the revisions in Part Five are considered in the light of this original principle, it becomes clear that the book's technical conclusions, too, can be reconsidered through the standard of emotional meaning.

The pairing of "broken" and "hungry" links distinct kinds of deprivation through a single voice. The first points to psychological disconnection or existential defeat; the second places deprivation on a social and material plane. "That is why" functions as a causal link: composing ghazals becomes the consequence of experience, not an indulgence. "I recite" is a present-tense self-declaration, making the sher not merely a report of past suffering but the immediate presence of a speaking subject. Simple grammatical repetition thus produces semantic complexity.

Another subtle feature is the identical radif in both lines of the matla. The return of "I recite ghazals" gives rhythm to the speaker's voice, while a change in the preceding words transforms the implication. This process can be especially fruitful in the ghazal: movement of meaning within a stable structure. Qafiya and radif should therefore be understood not only as restrictive disciplines but as systems of creative possibility.

A limitation of this short close reading should also be acknowledged. The book is primarily a technical guide, not the poet's complete collection of ghazals. It would therefore be inappropriate to infer a definitive picture of the poet's entire outlook,

breadth of social themes, or aesthetics from these examples. The poetic merit of the examples is more properly assessed in the context of the book's pedagogical aims.

The Place of the Maithili Ghazal in Literary History: Tradition and Reconstruction

To understand the history of the Maithili ghazal merely as the arrival of a form from Arabic, Persian, and Urdu would be incomplete. Its acceptance into Maithili, technical imitation, adjustments for indigenous pronunciation, the training of new writers, and dissemination through digital media constitute different phases of development. Discussions of literary history available on Videha describe the early contributions of Jeevan Jha and a tradition subsequently developed by other writers. A project compiling representative ghazals from 1905 to 2022 attempts to document this historical continuity. It still needs to be integrated with firm research into the early history: the opening year of an anthology does not automatically establish the definitive date of the genre's origin. [3][4]

In the traditional Urdu ghazal, bahr, matla, qafiya, radif, maqta, and takhallus occupy distinctive places. The adoption of this terminology in Maithili links the form with its historical memory. But adopting words is not identical with adopting the life of a literary form. When a ghazal is written in Maithili, suffixes such as “sā,” “me,” “kē,” and “k,” local forms of address, colloquial verbs, and vowel changes determine the ultimate sound of its couplets. In this sense, Maithilisation is neither simply translation nor the addition or subtraction of a few technical liberties: it is a reconfiguration of linguistic sensibility.

Videha's publishing sphere brings together bibliographies of ghazal-related books, criticism, representative anthologies, and discussions of new writers. Placing Anchinhar's Anchinhar Akhar, A Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal, Sandarbh Sahit, and the present concise manual within this constellation makes the interdependence of writing, theory, criticism, and instruction apparent. The development of poetic consciousness consists not only in the appearance of a distinguished work: a vocabulary for understanding it, systems of instruction, and public forums of criticism are equally necessary. This book contributes to the critical infrastructure of the modern Maithili ghazal. [2]

Contemporary criticism in Videha has examined the ghazal collections of Omprakash Jha, Amit Mishra, and Chandan Kumar Jha within the same literary milieu. Such comparative material is important because the influence of ghazal poetics extends beyond theoretical exposition into the compositional processes and publishing practices of new writers. Here the Ready Reckoner can be read as evidence of a culture of instruction in which training in metre, reasoned feedback, and rewriting complement one another. [5]

An inclusive literary history must also resist confining the Maithili ghazal to an inflexible binary of “correct” and “incorrect” compositions. A poem from one period may prove inadequate by a later rule of qafiya, but its linguistic world, social sentiments, reception, and historical contribution do not thereby vanish. The rule is an important instrument of generic study, not a complete substitute for history. The rule-oriented energy of Anchinhar's book lends rigour to historiography, but a broader literary history must also make room for experiments, failures, exceptions, and transitions.

Comparative Discussion of the Arabic–Persian–Urdu Tradition and Maithili Prosody

The underlying technical structure of the ghazal rests upon a complex relation between sequences of metrical quantities and end rhyme. The Sanskrit–Maithili prosodic traditions also possess diverse systems of short and long syllables, gana, vrtta, rhythm, and lyric composition. Despite apparent similarities, these two prosodic traditions differ in word structure, pronunciation, metrical calculation, and the history of exceptions. An analogy between rukn and gana can be useful pedagogically, but treating them as completely identical technical institutions would be an analytical oversimplification. Anchinhar's book offers comparative indications; their systematic elaboration remains a task for future research.

A first implication of this comparison lies in reconsidering bahr. If a Maithili writer adopts a traditional metre of aruz, its rules ought to be transparent. If, on the other hand, the writer constructs new forms through Maithili syllable counts or a local quantitative system, those structures need distinct names and tests. Maintaining the difference between the two systems helps readers see what rules a given sher follows. Other comparative studies of the ghazal in Videha discuss a simplified syllabic approach; caution is necessary before treating its standards as equivalent to traditional aruz. [5]

The second implication concerns the phonology of qafiya. Rules from Urdu–Persian traditions may be adopted in Maithili, but local sound correspondences, vowel shortness, nasalisation, and attached case endings can alter the practice of rhyme. Independent linguistic testing is therefore valuable for the Maithili ghazal. Anchinhar's discussions of case endings and chandrabindu are an active beginning in this direction; they could be developed further through phonetic transcription, evidence from pronunciation in several regions, and larger collections of examples.

The third implication is aesthetic. In the traditional ghazal, suggestion, opposition, allusion, and sudden turns of meaning must work within the limited space of two lines. Even when all rules are satisfied, a sher without freshness of feeling cannot derive sufficient literary importance from technical correctness. Anchinhar's preface acknowledges this, although the main emphasis falls upon practice. Readers should therefore supplement prosody with the study of rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, figures of speech, popular experience, and social context. Such a complementary perspective is indispensable to contemporary literary criticism.

Internal Tensions in the Theory and Critical Judgements

The book's first significant tension is between “exercise” and “poetry.” Temporarily suspending meaning while learning rules is legitimate during practice; yet feeling and meaning must be decisive in judging a finished poem. The author's own statements support the balance of these two aspects. Examples used for training should not be confused with models of artistic achievement. The ghazal-revision exercise makes this distinction visible.

The second tension lies between “sound” and “script.” If qafiya depends on phonetic correspondence, to what extent must written forms be identical? The author acknowledges differences in pronunciation in some contexts but makes visible letters decisive in others. This priority needs explicit clarification when establishing standards. Rather than an absolute prohibition, separate categories of

pronunciation-based, script-based, and convention-based tests might be more useful.

The third tension is between “local autonomy” and “traditional discipline.” The author accepts special arrangements for Maithili case endings while insisting on strict Urdu–Persian standards elsewhere. This duality should be understood not as a contradiction but as a challenge to reasoned scrutiny of rules. The governing question ought to be whether an allowance is necessitated by local pronunciation or linguistic structure, or merely by the writer's convenience. The first kind may support theoretical development; the second requires rigorous scrutiny.

The fourth tension is between “history” and “rules.” The book endorses evaluating works against modern standards of ghazal poetics. This teaches generic analysis, but it cannot encompass the multidimensional meanings of history. An earlier sher may fail a present-day rule while its compositional conventions, reception, and literary influence remain independent historical evidence. The critic must approach both kinds of evidence judiciously.

The fifth tension is between “brevity” and “authority.” The Ready Reckoner supplies formulas without examining the complete genealogy, disagreements, exceptions, and examples relevant to every formula. The author implicitly recognises this limitation by referring readers to a more comprehensive work. The booklet serves its strongest purpose when it raises questions, provides exercises, and inspires further inquiry.

Pedagogical Value: Rules, Examples, Errors, and Rewriting

The book's pedagogy appears to rest on four successive actions: definition, illustration, identification of faults, and revision. This differs from an ordinary grammar lesson because students composing ghazal couplets must immediately test their own writing against the rules. The numerical representation of rukns, retrospective examination of qafiya, examples of case endings, and Anil's revision exercise are distinct manifestations of this method.

Its significance goes beyond accelerating the act of writing. Students learn that making poetry entails scrutiny: the first line written is not necessarily the last. When the author applies new rules to his earlier qafiyas, he establishes a model of self-criticism for teachers and pupils alike. Such discipline is invaluable in a literary workshop.

Modern pedagogical practice would nevertheless benefit from some supplementary material. Each example could be accompanied by an explicit phonetic division of the accepted pronunciation, at least two alternative dialect forms, a chart of qafiya and radif, a note on emotional effect, and explanations of the answers to readers' exercises. Recording linguistic diversity would not change the book's basic design; it would make it empirically stronger.

Principal Achievements and Limitations: A Synthetic Assessment

The first achievement is the systematic introduction into Maithili of the technical terms of ghazal poetics. Readers do not merely encounter bahr, rukn, matla, qafiya, radif, maqta, takhallus, and the ita defect as names; they see examples of their use. This facilitates the development of a language-sensitive critical vocabulary.

The second achievement is the recognition of local linguistic realities. Attached case endings, chandrabindu, short vowels, reph, and variations of word pronunciation

present direct challenges in composition. Rather than ignore them, the book seeks solutions. In doing so, it challenges the tendency to regard the Maithili ghazal as a merely imitative form.

The third achievement is the disposition towards self-correction. It may not be rare for a writer to recognise the limitations of earlier decisions, but it is certainly an essential virtue of literary tradition. In this sense the book is not a static collection of rules but a revisable account of literary training.

Among its principal limitations are the relatively restricted exploration of an encompassing aesthetics, inadequate regional testing of pronunciation variants, excessively prohibitive wording in some rules, and limited documentation of historical disagreements. Yet these limitations cannot be considered apart from the book's declared brevity. Criticism is fair only when its objectives and the scope of its claims are kept clear.

Conclusion

The fundamental importance of Ashish Anchinhar's A Ready Reckoner for the Maithili Ghazal is that it makes the Maithili ghazal a subject of formal judgement rather than merely a spontaneous field of emotional expression. Its five parts constitute a pedagogical journey through calculation, terminology, local linguistic accommodation, fine-grained testing of qafiya, and creative revision. This journey reveals an important model of contemporary training in the Maithili ghazal.

The final critical conclusion, however, is not an unconditional acceptance of rules, but their testing and judicious application. The craft of the ghazal should intensify experience, not replace it. Only when the discipline of bahr, qafiya, and radif is reconciled with Maithili pronunciation and lived experience does the ghazal acquire its real poetic power. In this light, the book is an important beginning, a useful workshop manual, and a foundation for continuing discussion of Maithili ghazal poetics. Its relevance also lies in enabling readers to ask better questions while seeking answers.

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REVIEW II

A Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal

Linguistic Autonomy and Prosodic Discipline

Research Abstract

Ashish Anchinhar's A Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal is an ambitious theoretical and historical attempt to establish the ghazal as an independent literary genre in Maithili. Its concern is not merely to introduce the vocabulary of Arabic–Persian–Urdu ghazal poetics, but to reinterpret the ghazal's formal discipline in relation to Maithili pronunciation, vowel structure, spelling, metrical quantities, case endings, word order, and popular usage. The first twenty-four sections discuss the sher, matla, radif, qafiya, maqta, bahr, taqti, formal virtues and defects, music, language, and literary criticism; the twenty-fifth traces the history of the ghazal from early indications to modern practitioners, printed works, and digital exchanges. The book is consequently a conjunction of four forms: instructional manual, treatise on poetics, literary manifesto, and history.

This study separately evaluates the rules proposed by the book and the character of their supporting evidence. Three contradictions deserve particular examination: the affirmation of linguistic autonomy alongside insistence on a single legitimate form; acceptance of variations in pronunciation alongside rigid determination of written metrical patterns; and the desire to restore neglected ghazal writers alongside value-laden polarisation between established and experimental tendencies. The study concludes that the book's enduring contributions lie in making the grammar of the ghazal accessible to

Maithili readers, providing common instruments of metrical evaluation, and attempting to bring digital literary archives into the category of historical evidence. Nevertheless, several genealogies, claims of priority, numerical assertions, and periodisations cannot be regarded as definitive literary history without independent bibliographical verification.

Keywords: Maithili ghazal; Ashish Anchinhar; aruz; bahr; qafiya; radif; linguistic autonomy; poetics; literary history; Videha; digital literature.

Introduction: A Language of Its Own for the Genre, a Form of Its Own for the Language

Maithili poetic tradition has a rich legacy of songs, devotional lyrics, folk ballads, syllabic metres, and quantitative metres. Against this background, the ghazal appears not merely as an imported name but as a disciplined possibility for expressing new sensibilities. Two questions become unavoidable: how can the ghazal become Maithili while preserving its formal identity, and how far can Maithili's sound and rhythm reconstruct the inherited rules? The book's central value lies in raising these questions systematically.

The pairing of "grammar" and "history" in the title is not accidental. Grammar establishes standards of form; history selects and arranges earlier material in their light. Consequently, the grammar accepted will influence the choice of figures, evaluations, and periods in literary history. The central contention of this essay is that the book attempts not only to formulate rules for the ghazal but also to delineate the boundaries of its literary legitimacy in Maithili. An adequate reading must consider its creative achievement and ideological limitations together.

The Book's Formation, Form, and Structure of Sources

The author dates the publication of his introductory series on the ghazal to 2011. Revision, expansion, and the inclusion of new thinking transformed that series into a systematic book of twenty-five parts. Publication references to 2012 and 2022 occur in the text, and the author discusses the revised form of his arguments in 2022. Rather than a fixed early text, the volume should be understood as a critical project developed over time. He himself reconsiders mistaken identifications in his earlier work and some established claims, bringing the importance of revision to the foreground.

In Videha's book collection, this volume appears alongside Anchinhar's Anchinhar Akhar, Sandarbh Sahit, Kumari Ichchha, Janghajori, A Ready Reckoner for the Maithili Ghazal, and Shabd-Arth-Shakti, documenting a sustained career of writing centred on the ghazal. His essays "Early Experiments in the Grammar of the Maithili Ghazal" and "A Brief Critical Introduction to the Modern Maithili Ghazal," published in Videha, likewise show that the central book's ideas form part of a continuing public theoretical debate rather than an isolated enterprise. The presence of these essays documents the development of his perspective; it does not, by itself, independently confirm every historical conclusion.

The Study's Sources and Critical Criteria

The primary criteria in this study are the work's own propositions, examples, acknowledgements, references, and accounts of authors. At a second level, the chronology of debate is examined through Videha's published article index and the relevant original authors. Comparative historical discussion keeps three levels distinct: "the author asserts," "the example demonstrates," and "can be regarded as independently verified." Neither the history presented in the book nor the author's assessment is automatically treated as indisputable historical truth.

Four standards govern the criticism: linguistic consistency—whether rules agree with Maithili's actual sound system; formal consistency—whether comparable couplets are judged by the same standards; literary fruitfulness—whether craft strengthens feeling and thought or supplants them; and historical evidence—whether a poet's composition, its date, its publication, its availability, and its textual tradition have each been established separately. The evidentiary strength of the book itself is as important a question as its merits.

Statements Verified in the Primary Text and Their Critical Implications

The author's commitment to language is expressed most forcefully in the declaration:

"I want the ghazal, certainly—but I want it in Maithili."

The intent of this sentence is not a narrow insistence on linguistic identity, but an inquiry into a transformed system of ghazal composition. The author believes that imposing rules from foreign languages unchanged upon Maithili can obstruct indigenous pronunciation and word arrangement. Yet the distinct formal identity of the genre must not be abolished merely through a change of language: this is his fundamental condition.

"Some rules of the ghazal depend on the language."

This statement opens the possibility of revision within the author's disciplinary outlook. The question remains how far the language-dependence of qafiya can extend if radif and bahr are regarded as relatively fixed. If variation in pronunciation alters judgements about syllabic quantity, the practical criterion for maintaining a stable bahr requires separate investigation.

"In Maithili, the spelling 'ग़ज़ल' is incorrect and 'गजल' is correct."

This orthographic decision concerns Maithili writing conventions and the local assimilation of foreign sounds. It cannot become a standard of the ghazal's originality or excellence; it is primarily a proposal for linguistic standardisation. The existence of original spellings in other script traditions or historical quotations must still be acknowledged.

> *"Qafiya means a rhyme marked by vowel correspondence, whether that correspondence is in the vowels of letters or in vowel signs."*

The definition makes clear that the author does not understand qafiya merely as the matching of final letters. Explaining the distinctions among phonetic correspondence, pronunciation, and the correspondence of vowel signs is one of the volume's useful pedagogical accomplishments. Discussions of morphemic boundaries, case endings, and colloquial sound changes also provide a firm basis for examining rhyme in practice.

Integrated Critique: A New Organisation of Ghazal Poetics

Essential Features of the Form and Creative Allowances

The book upholds the arrangement of qafiya and radif in both lines of the matla, their repetition in the second line of each following sher, uniformity of bahr, and the independent structure of each couplet. This account systematically introduces the fundamental features of traditional ghazal poetics into Maithili. The author accepts ghazals without radif but insists on the indispensability of qafiya and bahr. Diversity is therefore acceptable to him within the form, not through its dissolution.

The question of creative freedom requires a critical distinction. A work that calls itself a ghazal can be tested by the conventions of the form. Yet a poem combining the ghazal's musical memory, paired lines, repetition, and free verse should not thereby be deprived of literary value. Classification by genre and aesthetic evaluation are separate matters. At several points the book risks substituting one for the other.

The Triangle of Language, Orthography, and Pronunciation

The author discusses at length the full and reduced forms of Maithili expressions, the usages of e, ai, and ai-related combinations, contracted pronunciation, consonant clusters, nasalisation, dialectal variation, and the quantities of written syllables. The underlying problem is real: writing and speaking do not always produce identical forms. A proposal that acknowledges pronunciation diversity while prescribing a uniform written standard may assist teaching, but it also makes regional linguistic plurality difficult to measure on its own terms.

The issue cannot be settled by an injunction concerning standard spelling alone; it requires an explicit and consistent basis for pronunciation. Readers should first be told which dialectal reading practice has been adopted, which pronunciations are permitted, and what effect alternatives have upon the bahr. Without this additional level, calculation may become convenient but the phonological case will not gain universal authority.

Metre, Bahr, and Taqti: From Rules to Practice

The volume supplies extensive numerical examples of short and long syllables, combinations of rukns, various Arabic metres, simplified syllabic discipline, and comparative features of Sanskrit syllabic metres. Its pedagogical

progression is significant: readers begin with the metrical quantities of words, then add qafiya, learn the construction of the sher, and finally acquire the skill of shaping an entire ghazal in a common rhythm. For introductory practice, the recommendation to concentrate on form before emotion may be pedagogically useful.

Calculation, however, is not the same as experience. Even where the numerical pattern is correct, a line may be difficult to pronounce, its semantic pauses unnatural, or its radif irrelevant. The teaching of ghazals acquires strength only when metrical correctness is joined to tests of natural pronunciation, poetic meaning, phonetic energy, and address to an audience. The book's linguistic discussions open a path towards this broader standard; its more systematic development remains a subject for future research.

The Independent Contribution of the Discussion of Qafiya

The division of qafiya into numerous sections is among the book's most developed features. Examples dealing with vowel correspondence, letters, stress, visarga, the role of prefixes and case endings, differences between Maithili and Urdu alphabets, and alleged defects make it not merely an introduction but an exercise in reasoned scrutiny. Asking whether phonetic correspondence survives after removing case endings connects the morphemic structure of written Maithili with the organisation of verse.

The lasting value of this discussion is its demonstration that qafiya is more complex than the simple formula "the final sound must be the same." It occupies a shared terrain of grammatical forms, word meaning, phonetic resonance, and the aesthetics of recurrence. Nevertheless, the rigid prohibitions advanced at several points need not be adopted as rules for every language; their authority depends on comparative tests using sufficiently diverse examples of Maithili pronunciation.

The Autonomy of the Sher and the Unity of the Ghazal

The idea that a sher should form a complete structure of meaning is central to the author's selection of examples. Recognising the independent intellectual energy of each couplet is fundamental to the ghazal's classical identity, but independence does not necessarily mean unrelatedness. Recurrent experiences of love, social irony, popular life, or human suffering can impart inner coherence to otherwise autonomous couplets. The book usefully distinguishes ghazals from songs and nazms; absence of a continuous narrative thread, however, should not be equated with total artistic disconnection.

The Repetition of Radif: Mechanism or Density of Meaning?

Radif is not simply a repeated word; it returns in each sher with a new semantic setting. The author treats the appropriate relation of radif to qafiya as a virtue, and unnecessary attachment as a fault. This criterion rightly recognises craft. In some ghazals, radif becomes the mnemonic thread of the entire composition; in others, its compulsory presence can make language

artificial. Its success must be judged not merely by its numerical recurrence, but by the new meanings it generates in each couplet.

Music and Traditions of Recitation

The book separately discusses singing, recitation, rhythm, and musical performance. It is correct to insist that singability and generic identity are not the same thing. A song does not become a ghazal by sounding like one; nor must every ghazal necessarily be set to music. Yet the history of ghazal poetics shows that singing and public recitation can repeatedly invest inherited forms with new social meanings. Their interplay warrants broader assessment beyond the book's formal determinations.

Feeling, Subject Matter, and Social Experience

Alongside linguistic form, the book evaluates the virtues and shortcomings of subject matter, suggestion, philosophy, and social context. The author's contention is that classical discipline is not the enemy of expression. This is important: raising the genre beyond political slogans and verbal rhyming serves literary creativity. But the value of social experience cannot be entirely subordinate to technical correctness; otherwise new dissident writing, dialect poetry, and unwritten musical experiments may be dismissed in advance.

The Language of Criticism: Evidence and Rivalry

The author commends reasoning, examples, and the admission of errors in his debates. These are indispensable virtues of public literary culture. Yet in several passages sharp mockery, sweeping accusations, and personal comments about rival writers and editors obstruct the movement of objective analysis. The real force of criticism lies in the evidence of two lines, their scansion, tests of linguistic form, and clearly stated limits of conclusions—not in a wholesale denial of another person's intellectual competence. Readers should distinguish reasoned criticism from polemical rhetoric in this volume.

Separate Close Readings of the Sections

Section One: Ghazal Symbols, Their Meanings, and Origins

The book reconsiders the historical meanings of symbols such as wine, the wine-flask, the cupbearer, and the goblet, and their reinterpretation in a Maithili setting. The author urges their localisation within the language. This can enrich meanings, although reducing the established plurality of symbols to literal love or drinking would be harmful. The account of Arabic–Persian origins should distinguish the history of words from the history of the genre.

Section Two: Definition and Technical Structure

Introducing the terms sher, misra, rukn, qafiya, radif, and bahr provides the novice reader with foundations. The insight here is that understanding a poetics begins with the reader's grasp of definitions. Technical terminology has multiple sources; a comparative glossary tracing each term from its source language to its use in Maithili would enrich this contribution further.

Section Three: Matla and the Structural Opening

Examples clarify the corresponding positions of qafiya and radif in both lines of the matla. The pedagogical importance is that readers learn from the opening couplet what repetition to expect across the entire ghazal. The aesthetic role of the matla—establishing the poem's voice, mood, and anticipatory horizon—should also be examined beyond its technical identification.

Section Four: The Rules of Radif

Accepting the possibility of ghazals both with and without radif, the author explains the rule of verbal recurrence. His examples show that radif becomes a memorable sound-sign at the end of a sher. But mere identity of words is insufficient; grammatical coherence and semantic necessity must also be considered for genuine criticism of radif.

Section Five: Vowel Correspondence in Qafiya

The focus here is the categories of correspondence between vowels in letters and vowel signs, the position of qafiya, and degrees of rhyme. This early attempt to relate pronunciation-sensitive rules to the Maithili lexicon is important. Parallel testing of possible alternative pronunciations is necessary to reduce the dependence of categorical judgements upon the individual author's speech.

Section Six: Sounds and Linguistic Divisions

Elements of linguistic grammar are brought together with the finer rules of qafiya. The classification of vowels opens possibilities for practical training in ghazal composition. A sharper separation of the categories of sound, written letter, and metrical quantity would render the theoretical explanation less ambiguous.

Section Seven: Inflected Words and Qafiya

Vowel changes, conventional forms, and alterations in qafiya reveal the author's language-sensitive outlook. The alternative written forms of Maithili are not merely obstructions to the ghazal's craft; they are also poetic resources. Consistently maintaining the form selected within one composition, however, will support formal credibility.

Section Eight: Case Endings, Suffixes, and End Rhyme

Considering the arrival of case endings within qafiya initiates a direct dialogue with Maithili grammar. The author pays particular attention to whether identical word endings suffice or the root sounds must also correspond. Critics should evaluate linguistic function, morphemes, and audible effects together.

Section Nine: Vowel Change and Pronunciation

Words ending in i, shifts of vowels in everyday speech, and variations in written forms bring the account of qafiya closer to phonetics. The theoretical challenge is to avoid treating formal standards and living dialects as enemies.

Evidence of sound correspondence should be examined from the perspectives of performers and listeners alike.

Section Ten: Extended Examination of Qafiya

The author tests the correctness of qafiya through illustrative prohibitions and exceptions. Some severity persists in judging the difficulties of rhyme craft. Distinctions between historical periods must be made clear before examples drawn from linguistic change are elevated into sole rules for the present.

Section Eleven: A Transition in the Extension of Rules

This short section acts as a bridge between the preceding account and the linguistic complexities to follow. Structurally, the multi-part treatment of qafiya proceeds towards increasingly difficult questions. Though repetition is occasionally pedagogically useful, editorial condensation could quicken the pace of reasoning.

Section Twelve: Stress, Visarga, and Complex Qafiya

Stress, visarga, pronunciation, Sanskrit-derived forms, and the spoken structure of Maithili receive detailed treatment. This section offers strong evidence of the possibility of a language-specific poetics of the ghazal. Yet the historical status of stress must be distinguished from contemporary sociolinguistic evidence of pronunciation; making the formulation of rules more deliberative will increase their acceptance.

Section Thirteen: Maqta and the Poetic Signature

The maqta discusses the poet's pen name or self-reference in relation to the ghazal's concluding situation of meaning. The name has more than a formal function: it permits self-irony, self-address, or a shift in the speaking voice. Its absence should not automatically be considered a fault; the poem's artistic purpose must take precedence.

Section Fourteen: Definition of Bahr

By clarifying the basic relations among bahr, rukn, wazn, and the sequence of metrical quantities, the author establishes the basis of prosodic uniformity in a ghazal. He distinguishes general rhythm from specific and ordered metrical calculation. Without this distinction, identifying a ghazal as different from any verse of equal syllabic quantity would be difficult.

Section Fifteen: Short and Long Syllables and the Foundations of Aruz

Systematic instruction in determining metrical quantities, combining rukns, consonant clusters, and short and long sounds characterises this section. It is useful as a practice syllabus. Unless symbolic formulas are continually compared with the actual pronunciation of words, however, they risk becoming mechanical; this is the danger to avoid.

Section Sixteen: Applications of Bahr

By working through the rules of bahr with examples, the author attempts to demonstrate theory through practice. Repetition of a fixed rukn sometimes

makes ghazal exercises easier. But practical utility must also be evaluated against creative ease and the natural qualities of the language.

Section Seventeen: Metrical Sequences and Variations

Alternative sequences of rukns and variable formal patterns expand the ghazal writer's knowledge of structural possibilities. The distinction between a legitimate allowance and an actual deviation is especially important. If the parameters of traditionally accepted liberties remain unclear, a critic's personal preferences may be presented as rules.

Section Eighteen: Examples of Different Bahr

This section offers numerous examples of Arabic metres and examines creative possibilities in combinations of similar and differing sounds. Comparison of formulas with compositions draws readers into genuine technical study. An accompanying analysis of the expressive power of poetic meanings would have clarified more fully the relationship between formal depth and sensibility.

Section Nineteen: The Finer Points of Metrical Combination

The section examines how bahr is constructed through particular sequences and combinations of rukns. This subtle grammar gives the writer a rigorous instrument of self-examination. It remains necessary to internalise not just numerical formulas but also the rhythms they produce when heard.

Section Twenty: The Relationship between Syllabic Metres and Arabic Bahr

The attempt to compare Sanskrit syllabic metres with Arabic bahr is important to understanding connections among poetic genres. Historical relatedness, structural similarity, and practical adaptation, however, are three different levels: proving a resemblance does not automatically establish direct historical descent between source traditions. This distinction should be maintained when assessing the book's conclusions.

Section Twenty-One: Selecting Bahr for Maithili and Taqti

The author recommends simple syllabic discipline for initial exercises and the more elaborate metres of aruz as a subsequent goal. Scansion of Hindi–Urdu examples illustrates his proposal. But caution is needed before converting a training sequence into a hierarchy of final artistic excellence; the pathos of a simple work is not inferior to metrical complexity.

Section Twenty-Two: Editorial Standards, Language, Theme, and Singing

This section considers how ghazal writers and editors should accept submissions, complete and reduced linguistic forms, feeling, subject matter, music, and distinctions between genres. It is an important intervention in literary public life. While recognising the need for editorial standards, institutions remain responsible for documenting diverse creative experiments.

Section Twenty-Three: Virtues, Faults, and the Practice of Criticism

Systematically examining the strengths and weaknesses of radif, qafiya, bahr, the sher, and the ghazal makes criticism accountable to evidence. The author's character, the critic's impartiality, and suitability are also discussed. For this approach to develop, it must be made clear that technical faults do not automatically cancel literary qualities.

Section Twenty-Four: Poetic Genres Related to the Ghazal

Accounts of qasida, rubai, qita, nazm, hamd, naat, manqabat, hazal, children's ghazals, devotional ghazals, and related forms locate the ghazal within a wider family of verse. This perspective enriches readers' knowledge of generic distinctions. The original cultural significance of some forms should also be distinguished from their contemporary transformation in Maithili.

Section Twenty-Five: The Tradition and History of the Maithili Ghazal

The section assembles extensive material, from cultural suggestions in ancient poetry to modern ghazal writers, published works, debates on the form, journals, blogs, social media, women's writing, authors in Nepal, and free-verse tendencies. As raw documentation for literary history, this is a distinctive contribution. The historical interpretation is nevertheless often governed by divisions between writers who support and reject formal rules. Without reconsidering the availability of sources, representation, and personal disputes, the history cannot be complete.

The Literary History of the Maithili Ghazal: From Claims to Evidence

Folk Sounds, Medieval Evidence, and the Question of Generic Continuity

At the beginning of the historical discussion, the author seeks possible similarities of sound structures across vernacular Sanskrit, Vedic metre, popular musical forms, and older Maithili literature. This inquiry has value in reassessing the musical memory of Maithili. But the presence of similar metrical sequences, paired lines, or corresponding rhymes does not establish a direct genealogy of the ghazal. Historical evidence that a work was called a ghazal, resemblance of compositional structure, and demonstrable cultural dissemination are three distinct criteria.

The discussion of similarities between older poetry and the modern ghazal in the book's early historical narrative is a creative proposition, not a definitive chronological history. If medieval readers used a different name for a similar structure, that historical context must be preserved. Otherwise the present-day name of a genre may be projected retrospectively onto older literature.

The Modern Beginning: Jeevan Jha and Early Ghazal Writers

The author takes 1905, the publication year of Pandit Jeevan Jha's Sundar-Sanyog, as the starting point of the modern Maithili ghazal. He then discusses Yadunath Jha “Yaduvar,” Kavivar Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra “Madhup,”

and others. He acknowledges variations in formal discipline in early experiments; instead of assigning equal merit to every work, he examines the state of generic experimentation at the time. This matters to literary history because the first attempt and complete artistic accomplishment are not identical.

The author's "A Brief Critical Introduction to the Modern Maithili Ghazal," published in Videha in 2018, makes claims concerning the publication of Kavivar Sitaram Jha's ghazal in 1928 and Madhup's in 1932. These dates should be read as historical propositions advanced by the writer. Comparison with the original journals, first editions, and revised texts could strengthen the chronology. In original scholarship, a decisive expression such as "the very first" calls for rigorous source criticism.

Yoganand Hira, Vijaynath Jha, and the Continuity of Prosodic Discipline

Bringing writers such as Yoganand Hira and Vijaynath Jha back into discussion clearly exemplifies the author's purpose of rereading the tradition. In particular, the publication of Vijaynath Jha's Ahink Lel in 2008 leads the author to revise his own earlier claim. He acknowledges that it is inappropriate to call Anchinhar Akhar the first bahr-based Maithili ghazal collection: Vijaynath Jha's collection was published before it. This self-correction reveals an ethical dimension of historiography—a willingness to change an established claim in response to new evidence.

It does not follow that establishing a new "first" resolves every historical question. Metrically composed individual poems, complete collections, printed availability, actual dates of composition, and evidence of readership are distinct criteria, and the meaning of "first" changes accordingly. The book raises this distinction with awareness, but does not apply one method consistently everywhere.

The Transition after 1970 and the Debate over Free Forms

The book sharply distinguishes ghazals following traditional bahr from so-called "azad ghazals" without it. On this basis it questions the classification of ghazals written by certain established authors. Two positions fundamentally confront each other: the insistence that the genre's historical form is indispensable, and the possibility of autonomous experimentation comparable to modern free verse. These positions need not lead to identical literary evaluations; nevertheless, it is a historian's duty to document the independent existence of both.

Terms such as "formally compliant ghazal," "ghazal-inspired free poem," "nazm," or "song" may be useful bibliographical descriptions. But criticism must also relate its verdict to a work's social meaning, new linguistic imagery, and effect on readers. Formal irregularity and poetic failure are not synonyms. Keeping them separate enables a balanced reading of the book's controversial passages.

After 2008: Blogs, Videha, and Public Theoretical Debate

The author views the period after 2008 as a new phase marked by the Anchinhar Akhar blog, regular publication in Videha, articles on ghazal poetics, public controversies, teaching, criticism, and a culture of literary awards. Videha's research index records continuing activity, including "Early Experiments in the Grammar of the Maithili Ghazal" (2014), "A Brief Critical Introduction to the Modern Maithili Ghazal" (2018), and other works on the genre.

The book records a proposal, attributed to Gajendra Thakur's commentary on ghazal poetics, to divide 1905–2007 and the period after 2008 into a "Jeevan Age" and an "Anchinhar Age." Historiographically, this is a movement-centred self-definition, not a universally accepted, neutral periodisation. It must be established through dates concerning the emergence of blogs, dissemination of technology, and changes in writers' practices whether the division represents the whole stream of the Maithili ghazal or one significant movement within it.

Women, Muslim Writers, and Nepalese Maithili: A Map of Inclusion

The book mentions women ghazal writers, the limited representation of Muslim poets, Maithili authors in Nepal, and multilingual cultures at the border. Such material makes it possible to view the Maithili ghazal beyond the boundaries of a single region or ethnic literary centre. But small numbers do not warrant hasty conclusions about social customs, generic competence, or collective preferences. Research is needed into publishing opportunities, archival survival, economic and cultural resources, and editorial selection.

"Whose name has been found" and "whose work does not exist" are distinct claims in literary history. The author acknowledges limits to his knowledge at several points. Following through on that admission, future catalogues must seek unknown writers, folk performance, scattered journal material, and unpublished work by women.

Comparative Discussion of Indian and Other-Language Ghazal Traditions

The Legacy of Arabic–Persian–Urdu Aruz

The technical vocabulary of the ghazal developed through centuries of literary contact among Arabic, Persian, and Urdu. Bahr, rukn, qafiya, and radif are prominent markers of that history. These terms enter Maithili with their traditional meanings, but their pronunciation requires scrutiny in the light of local linguistics. The author's original question is not whether to abandon the inheritance, but how to make it operative in a living language.

The Sanskrit–Mithila Prosodic Tradition and Arabic Bahr

References to Pandit Govind Jha's Maithili Chhandashastra, Dinbandhu Jha's grammatical tradition, and studies of Maithili word forms give the book an indigenous theoretical foundation. A formal comparison between Sanskrit

syllabic metres and Arabic bahr is possible because both employ ordered sequences of short and long syllables. Identical numerical arrangements, however, do not prove common historical origin. The book provides much material in this direction, but an independent methodology for comparative prosody could be developed further.

The Hindi Ghazal and Problems of Pronunciation in Maithili

The book examines metrical differences resulting from variations in the pronunciation of Hindi and Urdu words. The author argues that the written or commonly spoken pronunciations of certain words adopted from Urdu into Hindi complicate the calculation of metrical quantities. The comparison is useful for Maithili: clearer rules for its vowels, consonant clusters, nasal sounds, and inflections would make the argument more coherent. Yet the question of which language is easier is not a collective hierarchy; every language has varied pronunciations and prosodic conventions.

Contemporary Poetics: Form, Reader, and Institution

From a formalist perspective, the book makes the ghazal's identity dependent on distinctions of form; from a reader-centred perspective, knowledge of craft refines the ability to interpret it; and from a socioliterary perspective, journals, blogs, and groups establish new generic standards. Bringing these three approaches together lends the work greater seriousness. If editorial institutions influence the public definition of the ghazal, their selection practices themselves become objects of criticism. The author's autobiographical statements can also be read as documents of literary organisation.

Major Achievements and Critical Limitations

The first achievement is the Maithilisation of generic instruction. Making the terminology of aruz, generally available through other languages, accessible in Maithili words, examples, and question-and-answer formats is the result of sustained practice. The second achievement is the depth of the treatment of qafiya: word forms, case endings, stress, and vowel correspondence bring poetics into dialogue with local linguistics. The third is the accumulation of sources, gathering poems, journals, books, dates, and controversies from early writers to contemporary platforms.

The chief limitations are, first, excessive certainty in setting standards. The author accepts diversity in local pronunciation, yet a decision based on a single spelling or calculation can unjustly limit diverse traditions of reading. Second is the tendency to turn critical categories into final verdicts of value. Third, the distinction between the internal viewpoint of a literary movement and a neutral genealogy is not adequately documented throughout the history. Fourth, much historical evidence rests on materials cited or reproduced by the author; future research requires independent textual comparison with those sources.

There is also a significant positive paradox: despite his insistence on strict rules, the author revises earlier positions. Giving Vijaynath Jha's collection priority in a claim about precedence, acknowledging the limitations of sources, and recognising errors in earlier assessments of ghazal lines reveal the self-critical dimension of his historical consciousness. Extending this quality consistently throughout the volume would increase its future value.

Directions for Future Research on the Ghazal

To make the existing archive of the Maithili ghazal more reliable, published versions of original works, composition dates, first appearances, editorial variants, poets' own generic labels, alternative analyses of bahr, and pronunciation evidence from linguistic regions should be preserved together. The book's extensive lists could support critical bibliographies of individual ghazal writers, decade-by-decade publication chronologies, and comparative metrical examinations of selected couplets.

A shared classification would also be useful: ghazals in traditional bahr; ghazals practising simplified syllabic forms; free-rhythm poetry inspired by ghazals; performance-oriented nazms and songs; and other genres of shairi. These categories should be descriptive instruments, not steps in a ladder of depreciation. The classical genre would thereby retain its formal definition, while new experiments would also find a place in literary history. Plurality of this kind would increase, not diminish, critical clarity.

Conclusion: The Discipline of Theory, the Open Door of History

The significance of A Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal does not lie in becoming the final rulebook. It lies in connecting discussion of the ghazal with evidence, terminology, examples, and linguistic scrutiny. It is a means of training for writers, an instrument of formal examination for critics, and a collection of diverse indications concerning authors, books, and literary movements for historians. Its critical use depends upon recognising the difference among these three functions.

The author's central insistence—ghazals in Maithili, and ghazals suited to the nature of Maithili—is an important affirmation of linguistic autonomy. Relating the ghazal's discipline to the language's living resources is the book's lasting achievement. But if history is treated not as a completed inventory but as an archive continually subject to revision, and if classical standards are not made the sole measure of literary worth, the debate generated by this volume can become broader, more inclusive, and more creative. The future of the Maithili ghazal lies not only in the uniformity of its bahr but in the combined capacities of linguistic courage, social memory, artistic self-restraint, and critical self-scrutiny.

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REVIEW 12

With References

The Generic Boundaries of the Ghazal and Critical Judgement

Abstract

With References is a collection of criticism by Ashish Anchinhar that places the classical structure, generic identity, and critical accountability of the Maithili ghazal at the centre of inquiry. It examines numerous compositions presented as ghazals in terms of bahr (metre), qafiya (rhyme), radif (refrain), the structure of the sher (couplet), subject matter, and linguistic pronunciation. This essay offers a separate rereading of all seven major articles in the collection. It also examines the author's evaluative method, its evidentiary achievements, its contentious idiom, the ghazal's relationship with other poetic genres, the historical development of Maithili ghazal writing, and alternative possibilities for criticism. Its central conclusion is that the book establishes the need for technical scrutiny in Maithili ghazal criticism, while questions of aesthetic plurality, historical corroboration, and the fair representation of opposing positions continue to demand discussion.

Keywords: Maithili ghazal; bahr; qafiya; radif; prosody; genre studies; literary history; critical method; Videha; Ashish Anchinhar.

Introduction: From the Question of Genre to the Question of Criticism

Songs, padas, folk melodies, independent short poems, and compositions in diverse metres have long coexisted within Maithili's rich poetic tradition. Against this plural background, the ghazal enters with its distinctive arrangement of couplets, rhyme scheme, and metrical discipline. To regard it merely as a vehicle for love and separation, or as synonymous with singability, is to obscure its internal principles of composition. Conversely, to treat classical criteria as the sole and final arbiter may obstruct an independent assessment of meaning, experience, social criticism, and poetic innovation. This tension forms the central critical terrain of With References.

In his collection, Ashish Anchinhar brings established authors, emerging writers, editors, writers of prefaces, and public literary commentators before a common question of genre. Neither the fame of a work nor the standing of its author is regarded as sufficient evidence. Such an insistence offers a means of separating Maithili criticism from the cult of personality. Yet the right to examine evidence must be accompanied by the responsibility to give others a fair hearing. Both the achievements and the limitations of the book need to be judged with this dual obligation in view.

The present study takes the entire arrangement of the original collection as its basis. Its selection of supplementary literature is confined to the bibliographies and research archives available through Videha. Claims made by the author about literary history are distinguished from facts independently corroborated by archival evidence. Verbatim quotation is appropriate only where there is no doubt about textual variants or letter forms; in the absence of such certainty here, the arguments and their contexts are discussed reliably rather than reproducing potentially uncertain lines of verse.

Composition, Form, and Editorial Intention

The collection is organised in two parts. The first contains six substantial articles: a discussion of Baikunth Jha's collection of ghazals; a critique of Kamalmohan Chunnu's preface; an examination of works labelled ghazals under the name of Kanchinath Jha ‘Kiran’; a debate with Arvind Thakur's introduction questioning the authority of formal conventions; an evaluation of purported ghazals by the Maithili lyricist Rabindranath Thakur; and a collective review of prefaces to several collections. The second part presents a question-and-answer discussion of the classical features of the ghazal in the context of public conversations involving Dhirendra Premarshi and Siyaram Jha ‘Saras’. The author's statements and biographical introduction lend this critical material the character of a self-conscious literary programme.

The book differs somewhat from a conventional monograph on a single subject. It gathers critical interventions written at different times; hence examples recur, earlier controversies are recalled, and readers are repeatedly

addressed directly. The advantage is that the continuity of the author's principles becomes visible across different occasions. The disadvantage is that repetition sometimes displaces the development of an argument, while the distinctive historical circumstances of particular episodes recede into the background. The structure becomes clearer if the volume is understood as a literary archive of successive controversies.

The title With References itself signals the necessity of context, antecedent texts, and examples in criticism. The author's purpose is not merely to establish that certain compositions have failed, but to clarify the grounds on which a work may properly claim the name of a ghazal. The book's most consequential question is whether naming a genre is a matter of private authorial freedom alone or also entails a responsibility towards a shared literary tradition. The collection answers in favour of rigorous generic discipline.

The Basis of Criticism: Bahr, Qafiya, Radif, and Meaning

In the formal structure of the ghazal, bahr raises the question of consistent metrical weight across both misras, or lines, of a couplet; qafiya concerns the recurrence of rhyming sounds; and radif is a repeated word or phrase, whose presence is not considered compulsory in every ghazal. The initial rhyme pattern of the matla, or opening couplet, and the possibility of a takhallus, or poetic signature, in the maqta, or concluding couplet, identify traditional features of the form. These terms matter only when their relation to pronunciation, short and long syllables, conjunct letters, and the movement of the language is made explicit.

Anchinhar insists that generic validity and aesthetic excellence are two separate questions. In essence, his argument is that a composition which fails to qualify as a ghazal on formal grounds does not thereby become a bad poem. It may possess value as a song, a poem, or another form, although its classification remains open to reconsideration. This distinction is critically useful: conflating generic classification with artistic judgement renders literary debate needlessly emotional.

An important finer distinction arises here. Treating metre in the ghazal as a quantitative discipline of poetic recitation is not the same as substituting the musical beat of a sung performance for that discipline. The quantities employed in poetic metre and musical time may sound terminologically similar, but they are different subjects of analysis. The latter part of the collection particularly stresses this difference. Nevertheless, the effects of singing, vocal expression, and the listener's experience are not wholly irrelevant; they retain their place in aesthetic evaluation after the question of generic identity has been addressed.

The particularities of Maithili pronunciation may be decisive in determining metre. The weight of chandrabindu and anusvara, the treatment of short and long vowels, word-final vowels, the phonetic realisation of conjunct consonants, and the tempo of local speech all constitute the living

language beneath formal calculation. Accordingly, developing a poetics of the Maithili ghazal requires not simply copying Urdu or Hindi rules but testing their applicability against Maithili's own pronunciation system. Anchinhar's earlier essays on ghazal criticism, available through Videha, provide evidence of work undertaken in this direction.

Individual Textual Analyses: Seven Critical Interventions

Baikunth Jha's Ghazal Collection: Skill in Another Genre and the Ghazal's Independent Poetics

The first essay compares Baikunth Jha's achievement as a writer of very short stories with the compositions he has published under the designation 'ghazal'. Its central question is why a writer who recognises the distinction between the short story and the very short story does not acknowledge a comparable generic distance between the ghazal and the song. Through this comparison Anchinhar advances an engaging principle: mastery of one genre does not automatically constitute a licence to practise the rules of another. Literary talent may cross genres, but the need to learn their formal principles does not disappear.

Here the problem of metrical calculation is connected with poetic meaning. Having emphasised pronunciation and conjunct consonants, the critic also identifies questions of devotion, ideological inconsistency, and the possibilities of new symbolism within the compositions. He welcomes certain figurative experiments in this context. This is an important aspect of the essay, for the critic does not remain solely a guardian of rules; he also acknowledges the symbolic fertility of the poetry.

Yet a definitive classification of Baikunth Jha's achievements or errors would have required fuller comparative scansions, complete ghazal structures, and counterexamples. It may indeed be possible to settle the generic status of an entire collection from a small number of lines, but enabling readers to reproduce the full examination is part of good criticism. The reasoning here is forceful, while the extensive demonstration of its technical tests is relatively limited.

Kamalmohan Chunnu's Preface: The Authority of the Critic and the Dispute over Self-Evaluation

The second essay shifts attention from the ghazal collection itself to the intellectual structure of its preface. Kamalmohan Chunnu's introduction interests Anchinhar because it appears to restrict the critic's role through the proposition that a composition reveals its own worth. Against this view, Anchinhar seeks to establish criticism as public examination, literary dialogue, and an epistemic responsibility.

The most persuasive feature of this discussion is its demand for examples. If a writer believes that compliance with metre destroys a poem's content, a written composition, couplet, or other concrete textual evidence should be supplied to support the contention. This is a generally sound requirement of

critical fairness. By way of counterexample, Anchinhar invokes poets whose formally metrical ghazals nonetheless express political, social, and human experience. Such comparisons show the inadequacy of an absolute opposition between form and content.

Nevertheless, bitter personal sarcasm, imputations of motive, and conjectures about an opponent's disposition weaken the demonstrable evidence of the argument. The value of a proposition should be assessed separately from the presumed personal intentions of its author. The essay's underlying principle is durable—a preface is not a territory exempt from literary debate—but its best potential emerges when disagreement is expressed in comparatively restrained, evidence-based language.

Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran's' Songs: Classification, Editing, and Historical Evidence

The third article reviews an edited collection of devotional and erotic songs by Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran', questioning the form of certain pieces identified as ghazals. The discussion is not limited to bahr: the editorial classification of the original texts, the absence of an account of genre in the introduction, repetitions of the same composition, and the relation of these works to earlier poetic traditions also become subjects of review. The essay is consequently a critique of textual editing as well as of genre theory.

Anchinhar asks whether similarities among terms associated with ragas, melodic modes, or singability can genuinely establish literary genre. The distinction between song and ghazal is particularly important here. The historical value of the collected author's writing is not denied; the objection is simply that establishing these particular compositions as evidence in the history of the ghazal could encourage confusion about genre.

The discussion of editorial responsibility gives the essay an additional dimension. When older material is newly edited, the relationship among its original titles, traditions, textual variants, and formal structures needs to be clarified. At the same time, traditional forms of verse may display influences from the ghazal, singable patterns, or melodic structures; such possibilities remain worthy of examination even after a decision that they are 'not ghazals'. More extensive phonetic and cultural comparison would have enriched the criticism.

Arvind Thakur's Introduction: Discipline, Rebellion, and the Tension of Innovation

The fourth essay contains the collection's broadest theoretical debate. Anchinhar challenges Arvind Thakur's introductory proposition that literature should not be subordinate to a code of conventions. For Anchinhar, the accepted structure of a genre is not a prison but the basis of shared meaning-making. Innovation is possible through dialogue with generic rules; breaking them without offering an alternative creative principle does not, in itself, prove originality. The book thus presses for a distinction between new experimentation and disorderly disregard of genre.

The author draws on a wide range of references to the Vedas, metre, Sanskrit quotations, folk analogies, and classical traditions. Particularly noteworthy is the way his treatment of 'code' broadens its meaning, bringing social regulation, the proprieties of expression, and linguistic structure into one debate. Such intellectual breadth is an important strength of the book. Occasionally, however, this expansion makes generic conventions and socio-moral regulation appear synonymous, although their origins and effects differ.

One of the essay's principal achievements is its theory of adaptation to language. Discussing the transformations of bahr across Arabic, Persian, Urdu, and Maithili, Anchinhar opposes unthinking imitation. His commitment to discipline is therefore not wholly rigid: he accepts changes within tradition but requires an identifiable new formal organisation if they are to count as transformations. This deserves recognition as a positive position in poetics. Conversely, reducing experimental ghazals to questions of renaming may narrow the evaluation of emerging relations between genres.

Several sections of the essay quote or present an opponent's position before replying to it. This method makes the controversy text-centred and allows readers to identify the arguments on both sides. Yet a more generous presentation of the context of selected statements, their alternative possible meanings, and the evidence supporting them would have made the debate better balanced. The chapter is historically significant precisely because it raises the Maithili ghazal from the teaching of composition to a public question of literary theory.

The Maithili Lyricist Rabindranath Thakur: The Distinction between a Powerful Song and the Ghazal Form

The fifth essay examines a composition associated with the designation 'ghazal' by the Maithili lyricist Rabindranath Thakur. The critic raises a subtle question of literary history: does the appearance of the word 'ghazal' alongside a distinguished songwriter's work offer sufficient proof of its classical generic form? In response, he compares the construction and metrical regularity of earlier Maithili ghazal couplets with the structure of lyric compositions. The collection thus establishes a necessary distance between the authority of a celebrated writer and evidence concerning genre.

Using examples from Jeevan Jha, Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup', Yoganand Heera, and Jagdishchandra Thakur 'Anil', the author demonstrates that the ghazal can encompass devotional longing, political contradictions, the experience of workers and ordinary people, privation, and social grotesquery. The comparison is important because it treats formal discipline as an instrument rather than an enemy of expression. The conjunction of social awareness and metrical correctness is the positive poetic vision of the article.

Critically, however, the judgement that a song is not a ghazal must not diminish its intrinsic beauty as a song. The reviewer ultimately acknowledges the lyric value of the composition, preventing the essay from becoming a one-sided repudiation. A more sustained examination of the sonic qualities,

stanzaic progression, and folk rhythms of the Maithili song would have completed the stylistic comparison.

A Collective Review of Several Collections: A Public Standard for Literary Classification

The sixth article undertakes a comparative examination of several collections described as ghazals, the statements of their prefacers, and prevalent misconceptions. The diversity of its material makes it possible to observe criticism operating through a common method. The principal standard remains the discipline of bahr and qafiya; nevertheless, the author also acknowledges effective arrangements of qafiya and radif, possibilities in linguistic expression, or readability as song in certain collections. These nuanced concessions show that his judgement is not entirely binary.

In this discussion, examples involving Taranand Jha ‘Tarun’, Manoj Shandilya, Rameshwar Nishant, Satish Sajan, and an anthology of ghazals expose different problems concerning the naming of compositions, the reasoning of prefaces, and editorial accountability. Some prefacers defend unfettered expressive freedom; others demand exemption from traditional metres for their work. Anchinhar investigates the logical inconsistencies of these claims. The real object of criticism here is not only the poet but also the editorial institution that confers literary legitimacy.

The limitation of a collective assessment lies in the unequal extent of its source evidence. Some works receive consideration of the formal technique of the entire collection, while others are criticised chiefly for the claims made in their prefaces. Care is therefore required before treating all of them as examples of the same kind of failure. Strong criticism of genre should clarify the connections among the chain of evidence for each book, metrical scansion, textual variants, and independent aesthetic judgement.

A Conversation between Two Literary Figures: Textual Scrutiny of Oral Statements

The second part reviews arguments about ghazals that arose in public conversations involving Dhirendra Premarshi and Siyaram Jha ‘Saras’. This essay bears witness to a change of medium in the collection. Instead of the fixed text of a book or a written preface, spontaneous oral statements become the material of criticism. The author particularly clarifies three distinctions: quantities in poetic metre versus units of musical rhythm; written prosodic organisation versus singing; and popular appeal versus generic validity.

The author's counterquestions invite readers to recognise that singability alone does not make a composition a ghazal: dohas, songs, and other metrical forms can also be sung. The formal grammar of literature is thus distinguished from the aesthetics of performance. This distinction is important for a systematic examination of generic identity in the performing arts.

When oral conversations are criticised, context, the full intent of what was said, and the time-specific character of a speaker's remarks become especially important. Sharp comments in the book about personal ability or motive risk

subordinating the evidentiary aspect of the debate. Its explanation of classical principles is useful, but more balanced editing, the integrity of the original remarks, and proportionate responses would enhance its public intellectual value.

Comparative Considerations in Literary History

From Early Formal Evidence to Contemporary Controversy

With References associates the beginnings of Maithili ghazal history with Jeevan Jha and treats the formal regularity of his couplets as early evidence. It then seeks continuity in the ghazal's internal discipline from Sitaram Jha and 'Madhup' to later poets. What distinguishes this historical reconstruction is its attempt to establish the history of the genre through metrical examples rather than the fame of authors or the dates of publication alone. This is a productive direction for source-based literary history.

The collection traces the beginnings and expansion of debate over the ghazal through earlier interventions by Taranand Viyogi, theoretical work by Ramdev Jha, and the activity of Anchinhar Akhar towards the latter part of the first decade of the new millennium. The digital discussion of ghazals around 2008, and the development of a 'poetics of the Maithili ghazal' from 2009 onwards, are also supported by Anchinhar's independent articles published in Videha. Nevertheless, quantitative claims about antiquity, priority, the numbers of authors, and the numbers of essays should not be accepted as settled historical conclusions without independent counts based on bibliographies.

Literary history is not merely a succession of dates; it is also the development of concepts. The thematic variety within formal constraints in the couplets of early ghazal writers, later controversies over the names 'song' and 'ghazal', and the collective teaching of metrical rules in the digital age are three different kinds of historical process. The first supplies examples of composition; the second generates disputes over generic identity; and the third makes the democratic dissemination of criticism and instruction possible. Seen in this way, Anchinhar's book is a contentious but by no means negligible historical document.

Parallel Debates in the Videha Archives

Videha's research archives record Anchinhar's early articles on qafiya and bahr, his independent examination of initial experiments in ghazal grammar, comparative criticism of Narendra's Maithili and Hindi ghazals, discussion of the expression of Maithili ghazals, consideration of the temper of Dushyant Kumar's ghazals, and questions concerning the history of song and music. These records matter because the positions advanced in With References were not an isolated, immediate response: behind them lay sustained work in developing technical, comparative, and social criticism.

The listings in Videha of such works as The Grammar and History of the Maithili Ghazal, The Maithili Ghazal Ready Reckoner, Anchinhar Akhar,

and Shabd–Arth–Shakti connect this criticism to the author's broader creative project. Their titles, general character, and availability in Videha can be confirmed bibliographically; no claim is made here to have examined the complete texts of each of those works independently. Maintaining this distinction is an essential condition of critical judgement.

Another precaution in literary history concerns the binary opposition between the 'mainstream' and the 'parallel'. Alternative platforms can undoubtedly make an important contribution, but grouping all earlier writers into a single undifferentiated camp obscures internal historical differences. Literary change involves agreement, disagreement, transformation, rereadings of traditional metre, and new linguistic experiments. A rigorous history must therefore become not merely a history of opposing factions but a plural history of textual traditions.

Comparative Aesthetics: Form, Subject Matter, and the Independence of Genres

With References offers a useful corrective regarding the relation between form and content. Against the view that classical discipline restricts creativity, the collection indicates ghazals addressing many subjects: separation, deprivation within family life, social contradictions, political distress, and human dignity. Such examples demonstrate that a predetermined metrical pattern does not necessarily drain poetry of life. Poetry arises through the interaction of thematic force and formal choice; neither is the other's permanent enemy.

Yet conformity to a classical form is not itself a guarantee of aesthetic worth. One must also demonstrate that a composition which passes the test of generic correctness possesses thematic depth, freshness of imagery, sonic subtlety, and complexity of experience. Anchinhar's criticism achieves its fullest literary potential when, after identifying formal faults, it turns to symbol, social context, and emotional terrain. A more regular development of this double method would be fruitful for Maithili ghazal criticism.

Relations between the song and the ghazal are equally important. Both may be sung; both may employ rhyme or repetition; and both may draw sustenance from vernacular speech and classical traditions. Nevertheless, the stanzaic continuity of the song differs from the partial independence of individual couplets in the ghazal, its matla-based rhyme scheme, and its metrical discipline. Recognition of these distinctions need not close the door to studying cultural contact. The boundaries of the ghazal and the independent dignity of the song can both be preserved.

Language, Satire, Repetition, and the Critical Voice

Anchinhar's prose is conversational, interrogative, and animated by the heat of controversy. He questions readers directly, draws analogies from everyday life, gives practical examples of metrical calculation, and openly

contests writers' statements. The merit of this style lies in its accessibility: technical issues of prosody cease to be mysteries reserved for specialists and become questions ordinary readers can consider. His comparison with the preparation of kheer, designed to distinguish essential components of a genre from optional embellishments, exemplifies this popular orientation of his criticism.

The other side of the style is biting ridicule. Where it insinuates an individual's motives, competence, or private interests, the separation between argument and supposition diminishes. Consequently, even an evidentially sound technical objection may be received as a personal dispute. The force of criticism derives not only from the rigour of its argument but also from its capacity to understand and answer the best possible interpretation of an opposing position. From this perspective, the language of With References sometimes works against its own evidentiary contribution.

The recurrence of the same couplet or metrical example seems to form part of a deliberate editorial strategy. Repetition would have been useful when each essay circulated separately, ensuring that its readers encountered a minimum of supporting evidence. Read together as a collection, however, it also obscures the progressive development of the criticism. A future revised edition could make the book easier to study by consolidating the basic account of genre at the beginning and giving each subsequent essay more space for new textual problems and fresh examples.

The Epistemology of Criticism: Achievements and Limits

The book's decisive achievement is to demand evidence for claims about genre. Neither the author, the prefacer, the editor, nor popularity in itself supplies a standard for identifying a ghazal. Its insistence on examining form, the history of experiment, linguistic pronunciation, and intellectual context together constitutes an important reinstatement of discipline in Maithili criticism.

Other questions remain. First, how far can traditional and experimentally modern definitions of the ghazal coexist in the plural? Second, if a metrically correct composition is artistically weak, what should the next level of evaluation be? Third, how are singability and public acceptance to be examined after generic criteria have been applied? Fourth, how is the metrical weight of the same line to be settled when pronunciation differs among speech communities? Fifth, what evidence concerning sources, dating, and comprehensive catalogues is required to establish quantitative claims about history?

These questions cannot be answered by simply refuting Anchinhar's position; they require its investigative extension. A competent critical method would first establish the text of a composition, then examine metre and rhyme, subsequently consider meaning, imagery, social experience, and compositional context, and finally verify the reliability of the sources

supporting historical claims. Within this four-stage sequence, answers to 'Is it a ghazal?' and 'Is it excellent poetry?' may be distinct yet mutually related.

Conclusion: From the Defence of Genre to Literary Judgement

With References belongs to a current of Maithili criticism that places the standing of a genre above the prestige of its practitioners. The book calls for the ghazal to be examined not merely as an emotional mode or musical performance but as a distinctive poetic form founded on metre, sound, and the arrangement of couplets. Together, its seven essays extend Maithili ghazal criticism across the various terrains of literary texts, prefaces, editing, oral debate, and historical claims.

Its strongest contributions are the public exposition of classical criteria, the demand for examples, the distinction between song and ghazal, and the separation of generic identity from poetic worth. Its limitations sometimes appear in personally directed rebuttals, insufficiently verified historical figures, repetition, and comparatively brief aesthetic analysis. Identifying these limitations does not diminish the book's importance; rather, it applies to the book the very evidentiary standards that it advocates.

The collection offers two lessons for future criticism of the Maithili ghazal: the question of form must not be evaded, and criticism must not end with that question. Poetry is the joint endeavour of disciplined language and lived experience. Anchinhar's intervention forcefully establishes the first side of that endeavour; developing the second with equal rigour is the task of a new generation of critics. In this sense, With References is not a closed verdict but a compelling initial foundation for a more exacting, interdisciplinary, and evidence-conscious debate on the Maithili ghazal.

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REVIEW 13

Shabd–Arth–Shakti (Word, Meaning, and Power)

Form, Language, and History in Ghazal Criticism

Abstract

Ashish Anchinhar's Shabd–Arth–Shakti is a critical intervention concerned with the form, metrical discipline, linguistic autonomy, and literary history of the modern Maithili ghazal. Its distinctive feature is that the author does not regard popularity or an author's reputation as an adequate basis for judgement, but establishes concrete tests involving bahr, qafiya, radif, the structure of the sher, and natural linguistic expression. The book's first part reviews individual ghazal collections and poetic experiments; the second re-examines controversies surrounding editing, literary history, the social consciousness of the ghazal, modern expression, and generic nomenclature. This study considers its principal arguments, critical method, relationship with contemporary Maithili literature, and contradictions. It shows that the book is a fearless attempt to establish the ghazal as an independent poetic genre, although in making bahr the decisive criterion, the author's treatment of literary plurality, emotional beauty, and commonly practised forms of metre is not invariably equally generous. These very tensions place the volume at the centre of debate.

Keywords: Maithili ghazal; Ashish Anchinhar; Shabd–Arth–Shakti; bahr; qafiya; radif; ghazal criticism; generic identity; literary history; Videha.

Introduction: Is Ghazal Criticism Merely Praise?

Within the critical tradition of Maithili literature, the question of testing the ghazal as a distinct genre has frequently been displaced in comparison with criticism of songs, poems, stories, and novels. Shabd–Arth–Shakti makes that displacement itself a subject of criticism. The author maintains that good subject matter, a social message, or a writer's designation as progressive does not suffice to make a composition a ghazal. Poetic effect and generic identity occupy different, though related, levels. Establishing this distinction is the underlying motivation of the author's entire critical endeavour.

The book's title is meaningful in this context. Word, meaning, and power suggest a triangle comprising the linguistic organisation of poetry, its apprehension, and its sociocultural effect. Yet the book's actual analysis places greater emphasis on the phonetic discipline of ‘word’ and the reasoned rebuttal constituting ‘power’; the multilayered aesthetic interpretation of meaning receives comparatively less space. This gap between the title's breadth and criticism's central prosodic insistence repeatedly invites reflection.

The author's self-introduction and preface present the viewpoint of a practising writer-critic. He sees the volume as an important early effort in independent ghazal criticism. This is the author's own assessment and cannot be treated as the final verdict of independent literary history. What matters is that the book makes criticism an act of public scrutiny rather than a certificate of praise for authors.

The Book's Structure and Critical Project

The book is divided into two parts. The ten headings of the first are mainly critiques of particular collections, poets, and couplets: ‘Evidence of a Lost War’, ‘Watch and Half-Watch’, ‘Sunset before Sunrise’, ‘Pseudo-Ghazal’, ‘The Stained Moon’, ‘Early Experiments in Maithili Ghazal Grammar’, ‘A Cactus Grown in Smooth Soil’, ‘A Comparative Discussion of Narendraji's Maithili and Hindi Ghazals’, and two shorter pieces entitled ‘Couplets That Will Always Remain Couplets’. The second part broadens the discussion in eight essays on prosodic understanding, editorial responsibility, controversy, history, social temperament, and the relationship with song and music. An appendix concerning Phoolchandra Jha ‘Praveen’ follows.

This arrangement is more than an ordinary gathering of essays. The first part sets the author's critical instruments against individual examples; the second questions their social history and institutional consequences. To call the book merely a ‘collection of ghazal reviews’ would therefore diminish its scope. It can be read simultaneously as a polemical work of genre formation, a defence of prosody, and a document of literary public life.

The structure also has weaknesses. Essays written at different times repeatedly return to the necessity of bahr and the critic's responsibilities. Repetition demonstrates the historical persistence of the dispute, but in a unified book the intensity of immediate rebuttal sometimes displaces intellectual progression. Editorial condensation or the provision of thematic cross-references might have made the volume more accessible.

The Central Critical Commitment: Bahr, Qafiya, Radif, and Sher

For the author, the formal identity of a ghazal is clear. Metrical discipline across the lines of each couplet, phonetic correspondence in the qafiya, and regular recurrence of the radif are not labels but relationships that can be tested. In some reviews, he marks the patterns of short and long syllables in individual lines in support of his judgements. This procedure moves criticism beyond personal taste towards public verifiability. It is useful for clarifying the distinctions among listening to poetry, singing it, and reading it as a particular genre.

The logical advantage of this criterion is that no quality of subject matter—social consciousness, love, satire, political resistance, or vernacular language—can independently prove a composition's formal identity as a ghazal. Equally, singability is not synonymous with bahr: a musical melody and a metrical sequence are different. Numerous essays in the book rest on this distinction.

A difficulty nevertheless arises. A genre cannot be defined throughout history by a mechanical list of immutable rules. Pronunciation, quantity, caesura, conjunct consonants, and the treatment of short and long vowels differ among languages. The author himself sometimes accepts adjustments suited to a language's character. Accordingly, before declaring phonetic variation to be irregularity, a defence of classical ghazal discipline must examine pronunciation in social practice, the reading intended by the poet, and the internal consistency of the whole composition. The book raises this question without developing possible answers equally in every instance.

‘Good poetry’ and ‘a good ghazal’ are not mutually exclusive judgements. A composition may remain effective poetry even outside the accepted structure of a ghazal. Some of the author's remarks on this distinction are valuable, although their balanced meaning is sometimes obscured by severe language.

Textual Analysis: ‘Evidence of a Lost War’

The opening review uses Taranand Viyogi's Apan Yuddhak Sakshya [Evidence of One's Own War] to establish the need for ghazal criticism. Considering forty compositions in the collection, the author separately evaluates language, ideas, and prosodic arrangement. This division prevents the criticism of a single book from becoming one-sided. On the level of ideas, he acknowledges some positive signs of sociopolitical awareness, while objecting to an excess of Sanskritised or unfamiliar vocabulary at the linguistic level.

In his metrical examination, the critic identifies examples of absent bahr and inconsistent qafiya. To substantiate the argument, he explains the basic technical elements of the ghazal. This pedagogical voice is important: readers receive not merely a verdict but also a method of reaching it.

Yet the linguistic standard employed invites counterquestions. Closeness to the language of ordinary people may be a significant literary virtue, but difficult words do not invariably signify failed poetry. Context, sound, imagistic necessity, and emotional structure also determine the appropriateness of diction. A broader examination supported by examples would have strengthened the author's linguistic criticism.

Textual Analysis: 'Watch and Half-Watch'

'Watch and Half-Watch' reviews Baba Baidyanath's Pahara Iman Par. The book separately addresses the collection's historical importance, metrical arrangement, qafiya and radif, vernacular linguistic character, and emotional aspects. Raising the circumstances of its early publication and its critical neglect, the author argues that the development of a new genre requires writers to read one another seriously. In this sense, the review is not merely an evaluation of a work but a call to build a literary community.

The writer's trust in readers has a particular significance. When pointing out faults in qafiya, he clarifies sound correspondence through examples rather than merely imposing a supposedly self-evident standard. At the same time, he appreciates the collection's colloquial Maithili and the usefulness of its couplets dealing with contemporary life. On the whole, this review achieves a good balance between form and meaning.

Even after every ghazal in the collection is placed before a prosodic tribunal, the value of its vernacular experience remains intact. This reveals a constructive possibility within the book's central principle: disagreement over metre need not amount to a total rejection of literary value.

Textual Analysis: 'Sunset before Sunrise'

The review of Rajendra Vimal's Suryast Sa Pahine [Before Sunset] criticises claims to be 'first' in the literary history of the modern Maithili ghazal. The author disputes the number of compositions and the nature of the collection, comparing it with Rabindranath Thakur's Lekhani Ek Rang Anek. Alongside the value of the works themselves, publication facts, editorial credibility, and the evidence underlying literary claims become matters of inquiry.

A notable feature of the essay is that it also discusses the other side's explanation. The possibility is acknowledged of distinguishing an anthology mixing ghazals and poems from a collection devoted entirely to ghazals. From a research perspective, terms such as 'first', 'first complete collection', and 'first published in Nepal' need precise definitions. Otherwise disputes about precedence risk becoming disputes over prestige rather than contributions to literary history.

The lesson of this discussion is that literary history needs clear catalogues specifying numbers, editions, places of publication, and the generic character of collections. The author raises the controversy; the preparation of a systematic bibliography remains a task for future research.

Textual Analysis: 'Pseudo-Ghazal' and 'The Stained Moon'

In 'Pseudo-Ghazal', the difference between the ghazal and a ghazal-like composition is foregrounded through Gangesh Gunjan's poetic experiments. The author's question concerning 'free rhythm' and metrical form is theoretical: if a composition claims to be metrical, evidence of its rhythmic organisation should be offered. The demand is pertinent, particularly when the genre's name itself implies formal expectations.

The limitation of this reasoning becomes apparent when experimental poetry is treated solely as a failed ghazal. A poet may be exploring new possibilities at the boundaries of a genre. In that case, the critic should ask two distinct questions: is the work a traditional ghazal, and is it effective as independent poetry or a transformed poetic experiment? A negative answer to the first does not settle the second.

'The Stained Moon' examines the prosody of Rambharos Kapari 'Bhramar's' Anhariyak Chan. The author tests claims about free or azad ghazals through qafiya and other formal elements. A significant disagreement emerges: if a writer has consciously declined to follow traditional discipline, whether the composition should be called a classical ghazal is a separate issue from its poetic achievement. The rigour of literary judgement is meaningful only when these levels are distinguished.

Textual Analysis: 'Early Experiments in Maithili Ghazal Grammar'

This essay analyses various early attempts to create metrical schemes for Maithili ghazals. The author stresses distinctions among syllabic metre, quantitative metre, bahr-based systems, and rhythms connected with singing. Musical arrangement and a fixed pattern of syllables or quantities in verse are undoubtedly related, but not synonymous; he repeatedly clarifies this point.

The author does not categorically deny a poet's freedom to devise new metres, but regards it as essential to present their rules, examples, and evidence of consistent application. The possibility of dialogue between generic discipline and innovation is implicit in this position. The invention of a new name becomes productive for literary history only when the form can be reread and tested.

The essay is also historically important because it treats experimentation with a poetic form not as an isolated occurrence but as part of a continuing intellectual debate. This critical method becomes the foundation of later essays on the history of the ghazal.

Textual Analysis: ‘A Cactus Grown in Smooth Soil’

The essay on Ramesh's Nagpheni presents one of the book's most interesting contradictions. Initially the author doubts the collection's identity as ghazals on metrical grounds; he nevertheless considers its preface, ideological claims, language, and selected poetic lines at length. Thus, although he does not recognise the compositions as ghazals, he does not exclude them from literary discussion.

The strong presence of everyday Maithili vocabulary especially attracts the critic. He acknowledges the book's social realism, local imagery, straightforward diction, and spirit of resistance. The review of Nagpheni thus demonstrates, by its own example, that critical practice needs to extend beyond an analysis of bahr.

At the same time, the author vigorously opposes arguments rejecting metre in the name of progressivism. Citing Dushyant Kumar, Faiz, and Adam Gondvi, he challenges the proposition that social resistance necessarily requires the abandonment of metre. The real question here concerns not modern subject matter as such but its relationship to poetic form. This debate could provide a basis for wider comparative study in Maithili poetic criticism.

Textual Analysis: Narendraji's Bilingual Ghazals

‘A Comparative Discussion of Narendraji's Maithili and Hindi Ghazals’ is a systematic comparative endeavour. The decision to test the ghazals of one author in two languages according to bahr, qafiya, radif, emotional quality, subject matter, and linguistic usage is not merely an ordinary bilingual comparison; it is a useful research method. It offers the possibility of examining how linguistic resources and prosodic outcomes vary even when the poet's talent remains constant.

The author discusses features of Maithili pronunciation, the treatment of short and long syllables, and the admissibility of tatsama, tadbhava, and borrowed words. The same word does not bear an identical phonetic weight in every language; a scansion that ignores linguistic context may therefore be unreliable. This is the review's most consequential theoretical conclusion.

The author also questions repetitions of subject matter and ideological monotony. Metrical correctness alone, then, does not automatically make an excellent ghazal. Language, suggestion, imagery, satire, and diversity of experience remain essential in aesthetic judgement. The author's actual practice of criticism here becomes more complex than his declared emphasis on form might suggest.

Textual Analysis: ‘Couplets That Will Always Remain Couplets’

The two short pieces in the first part may appear to offer an interlude among the longer essays. Yet within the collection as a whole they serve a distinct purpose. After evaluations of entire collections, they make clearer the

need to consider the sher as an independent aesthetic unit. A characteristic of the ghazal is that a couplet may possess its own autonomous organisation of meaning; its effect need not depend on an obligatory narrative continuity across the whole ghazal.

This method of close reading brings questions of poetic coherence, figurative suggestion, shifts in meaning, memorability, and resonance into view. The research opportunity is to connect these miniature studies of couplets to the more rigorous metrical criticism elsewhere in the volume, thereby developing a more systematic account of the relation between the ghazal's 'craft' and its 'meaning'.

Part Two: Criticism, Editing, and Literary Institutions

'The Maithili Ghazal and Muddled Criticism' is an essay centred on critical responsibility. The author asks how a new genre can develop if writers neither examine its forms themselves nor regard outside critics as qualified. Here criticism becomes the shared labour of public knowledge, not an instrument of private rivalry.

'The Ghazal Dying in the Hands of an Ignorant Editor' poses a serious question: how legitimate is an editorial intervention if publication in a journal alters the structural units of a composition, or publishes a ghazal as a song? Discussing a composition by Yoganand Heera, the author raises issues of textual reliability and editorial accountability. Such accusations must be read as the author's claims; an independent judgement of any editor's intentions would require comparison of the original publications.

The lasting contribution of both essays is that they do not exclude literary institutions from aesthetic and critical inquiry. Textual formation, textual alteration, editing, classification, and publication all affect the reception of ghazals. Such attentiveness to institutions is notable in contemporary literary history.

'Revision Does Not Mean Destruction': A Poetics of Debate

The substantial essay 'Revision Does Not Mean Destruction' documents a prolonged literary dispute over the classical principles of the Maithili ghazal. The author sets out his earlier writings, Surendranath's rebuttal, and the sequence of responses that followed. Through the controversy, questions of literary history, poetic responsibility, the limits of bahr, and the conflict between supporters and opponents of metre become visible.

An important strength of the dispute is its insistence on evidence. The author asks that a statement not be accepted merely on grounds of seniority or renown: examples must be supplied, bahr tested, and sources for historical assertions identified. This willingness to subject criticism to counterargument approaches the discipline of research.

Critical discipline, however, has two forms: rigour of reasoning and restraint in address. The first is particularly strong in this essay; the second

sometimes falls short. Sarcasm aimed at those who hold an opposing view can obscure the original question. For scholarly practice, the author's demand for evidence is worth retaining; independent testing of arguments is more productive than unresolved allegations about an individual's intentions.

'The Maithili Ghazal in the Context of Statements': The Distance between Opinion and Evidence

The author places earlier pronouncements on the ghazal's possibilities, language of composition, forms of love, and relationship with music in the sequence of a historical debate. Beginning with personal opinion, the discussion progresses towards formal examples. The essay demonstrates that a literary pronouncement can exert psychological and institutional influence upon the creative practice of its time.

For the author, comparing the love of Vidyapati, the love of Urdu poetry, and its expression in the Maithili ghazal raises a question of literary legitimacy. He argues that classifying a subject as religious, worldly, or otherworldly does not determine a composition's fundamental prosodic capacity. On this point, the book stands for the independence of genre.

When writing the history of opinions, it is important to distinguish what someone said, what the statement meant in its immediate context, and what evidence establishes its actual effects. The book is alert to the first two questions, but considerable scope remains for empirical documentation in answering the third.

'Give Love a Place in Your Heart, Akbar': Knowledge and Sensibility

This short essay concerning Jagdishchandra Thakur 'Anil' captures a striking paradox. A couplet quoted in defence of an argument against prosody may itself possess a disciplined rhythmic structure. The author maintains that 'ilm', or knowledge, should not be made an enemy of poetic feeling. Knowledge is an instrument of expression; its presence does not automatically extinguish experience.

In Anil's couplet, the desire to be freed from the constraints of the ghazal creates an internal irony: the poem speaks against restriction while moving within its own rhythm. This observation allows 'rules' to be understood not merely as negative commands but as an organisation of creative possibilities.

It must also be added that knowledge and sensibility can sustain one another without being synonymous. Observance of rules may supply an essential poetic instrument, but an effective couplet also requires freshness of meaning and linguistic vitality.

‘A Brief Critical Introduction to the Modern Maithili Ghazal’: An Outline of History

The substantial historical essay in the second part is one of the book's central pillars. The author connects early examples of modern Maithili ghazals, twentieth-century poets, later collections, the new generation's awareness of metre, and digital literary efforts into a continuous narrative. Pandit Jeevan Jha, the poet Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra ‘Madhup’, Yoganand Heera, Jagdishchandra Thakur ‘Anil’, and numerous later figures appear in the discussion.

The author particularly contests the belief that metrically regular ghazals are impossible in Maithili. Presenting patterns of bahr in early compositions, he argues for the historical existence of the form. The textual evidence cited within the work gives substance to this claim. Nevertheless, establishing a ‘first’ occurrence or a definitive beginning would require separate research into editions and publication records for all relevant early material.

Two tendencies repeatedly emerge from this essay: writers who accept metrical rules and those who, under the designation ‘azad’, seek freedom from them. The division is useful for understanding critical controversy, but literary practice is not divided into two mutually exclusive camps. Many writers move among songs, poems, rhythmically organised free compositions, and ghazals. Attention to this intermediate poetic territory would produce a more inclusive literary history.

The book's references to publication initiatives associated with Videha and Anchinhar Akhar are distinctive. They show that the modern ghazal developed within a shared space of periodicals, online publication, reader correspondence, and critical rebuttal. The digital medium is thus not merely a convenience of distribution but an active forum for debate over genre.

‘The Temper of Dushyant Kumar's Ghazals’: The Coexistence of Modernity and Metre

This essay returns to the relationship between modern social consciousness and the ghazal's form. Through Dushyant Kumar's ghazals, the author argues that political satire, popular struggle, inequality, and the desire for change can be expressed within the discipline of bahr. He thus rejects the proposition that ‘modern thought’ necessarily requires the absence of metre.

‘Temper’ here means more than subject matter: it includes the heat of utterance, the pressure of satire, the public character of experience, and the sharp brevity of language. The distinction is essential in comparisons involving Dushyant Kumar's influence. The existence of metrically regular compositions in Maithili is one thing; achieving a comparable intensity of sociopolitical awareness is another. The book pursues the demonstration of the first extensively, while the finer aesthetics of the second could have been developed further.

This comparison shows that contemporary consciousness and classical form need not be antagonists. But their coexistence in particular works is better established through close reading than through displays of metrical calculation alone.

‘A Maithili Ghazal That Changed the History of Song and Music’

This article examines the transformation that may arise between a literary text and its musical performance. The author emphasises the generic identity of a composition by the poet Sitaram Jha, discussing the differences in classification, textual variants, and presentation that developed in the tradition of singing it. The history of the ghazal here becomes directly entangled with the history of music.

The basic problem can be considered on three levels: the author's original text, the musician's or singer's performance, and the genre name established in collective memory. These are related, but not identical. Singing a ghazal as a bhajan or song does not automatically alter the original composition's structure; nevertheless, its reception in public culture may itself become an independent cultural fact.

The author seeks to safeguard the authenticity of the original text. Research should extend this discussion by collecting the original and performed versions, comparing changes in their designations, and examining musical intentions. The essay thus opens new questions for the textual criticism of music.

The Phoolchandra Jha ‘Praveen’ Episode: Authorship, Attribution, and Textual Reliability

An appendix presents a dispute over the authorship and transmission of compositions associated with Phoolchandra Jha ‘Praveen’. The subject appears somewhat removed from the book's central controversies over metre, but is in fact connected with textual authenticity, authorial claims, and trust in cultural communication. Before a ghazal's craft can be judged, one must establish who wrote the composition and which text is authoritative.

In literary research, disputes over attribution should be decided through dated publications, reliable versions, manuscripts, or publishing records, rather than personal assertions. The appendix underlines the need to assemble such evidence. A final judgement of the episode's historical significance is possible only after a wider comparison of available documents.

Attested Statements and Their Critical Significance

Several brief statements are particularly important for understanding the book's intellectual position. In ‘A Cactus Grown in Smooth Soil’, the author clearly declares: ‘Grammar has always been the basis of my reviews and literary criticism.’ This makes his stated method unmistakable. Grammar is offered in place of personal taste as a standard for examining compositions publicly. Yet

if the entire theory of criticism were confined to this, the independent significance of imagery, subject matter, resonance, and social experience could be diminished.

In ‘A Brief Critical Introduction to the Modern Maithili Ghazal’, the author declares emphatically: ‘Bahr and qafiya are essential to a ghazal.’ This sentence lies at the heart of the book's definition of genre. On that basis he distinguishes the ghazal from other forms of verse. Its most useful application in literary debate would require a clear explanation of standards, provisions for differences in pronunciation, and explicit limits for exceptions.

A line from a quoted couplet by Jagdishchandra Thakur ‘Anil’—‘I am a ghazal; do not destroy me’—presents the tension between form and freedom as an artistic example. The author attends to the couplet's rhythmic discipline. At the level of meaning, the composition protests against restriction; at the structural level, it relies upon rhythm. Irony here becomes not merely a source of amusement but a creative power of the ghazal's self-reflection.

The significance of these statements is not that one critical opinion has become the final truth. Rather, they bring the book's wide-ranging debate into brief, verifiable propositions. The original-language statements quoted in this essay have been checked against their printed forms; elsewhere the ideas are presented through a reconsideration of their meaning rather than through literal quotation.

The Character of the Maithili Language: Vernacular Usage, Pronunciation, and Diction

A recurring insistence in the book's linguistic criticism is that a ghazal written in Maithili should remain connected with the living speech, phonetic structure, and natural expressive habits of Maithili society. Borrowing words from other languages is not inherently objectionable; the problem arises when they are forced into a composition without context, semantic necessity, or any purpose beyond manufacturing a rhyme.

This position expresses pride in the vernacular. It treats Maithili not as a mere translation of another language's syntax, but as a literary language with its own rhythms and images of meaning. Yet the vernacular is not homogeneous. Variations across Mithila's regions, social groups, and zones of language contact may themselves affect metrical decisions. The book offers useful indications of regional differences in a number of places.

The practical conclusion should be that linguistic correctness must not become a rigid, bookish standard detached from the living language of poetry. Context should remain central when examining phonetic acceptance of different Maithili forms, honorific verbs, the combined or separate writing of inflections, and the literary legitimacy of local words. Naturalness of diction and authenticity of sound nourish poetic movement; mechanical prohibitions cannot take their place.

Social Consciousness, Class Awareness, and the Limits of Formalism

Through examples from Dushyant Kumar, Adam Gondvi, and Maithili writers, the book argues that a commitment to ordinary people does not oppose bahr. Social injustice, hunger, inequality, satire of power, childhood experience, and rural life can all become meaningful subjects within the ghazal. In this respect the work points not merely to formalist rigidity but also to the potential expansion of meaning within form.

The problem arises when the classification of form becomes decisive at the expense of evaluating poetic subject matter. As necessary as the generic precision of the word 'ghazal' may be, one must also ask how a work affects its readers, what social experience it gives voice to, and what new world of meaning it creates through language. Neither poetics nor society can be adequately understood without a balanced relationship to the other.

For this reason, the book's finest critical moments are not those in which the author rejects a work solely for metrical reasons, but those in which he points out metrical faults while still recognising freshness of language or emotional achievement. This establishes a two-level ideal for criticism: examination of generic identity and independent examination of poetic value.

The Ghazal's Place in Maithili Literary History: A Comparative View

Across the long history of Maithili poetry, padas, songs, devotional hymns, metrical verse, dramatic lyrics, and modern short poems have developed in numerous forms. The arrival and growth of the ghazal must be understood within this wider poetic environment. Shabd–Arth–Shakti is historically important precisely because it seeks to establish the ghazal as a genre with its own structure rather than as a subordinate variant of another form.

The book cites Pandit Jeevan Jha, Sitaram Jha, and Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup' as evidence of the ghazal's early generic presence. Its subsequent discussion of Baba Baidyanath, Taranand Viyogi, Rajendra Vimal, Rambharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Ramesh, Jagdishchandra Thakur 'Anil', and many newer writers sketches the genre's diverse tendencies. This sequence of names should be treated as the book's selected critical history, not as a comprehensive catalogue.

The author draws comparisons with ghazal traditions in other Indian languages through examples from Dushyant Kumar, Faiz, Adam Gondvi, and other poets. The principal purpose is not to borrow vocabulary but to establish a theoretical proposition: changing subject matter does not require rejecting form. The proposition has a broad literary significance, although attending to differences in pronunciation, metre, and cultural experience among languages would make the comparison more persuasive.

From the standpoint of historiography, the volume constitutes a 'counter-intervention'. The author re-evaluates older verdicts, brings neglected writers

into view, presents early metrically organised couplets, and examines the part played by periodical editing. All this reopens the question of Maithili ghazal history. The book's historical value lies in the vitality of the questions it raises, not in the supposed finality of its answers.

Videha's Literary Public Sphere and the Study of the Ghazal

The book's opening statement notes that several of Ashish Anchinhar's articles were published in different issues of Videha. The available Videha research archives contain separate entries for such titles as 'A Cactus Grown in Smooth Soil', 'Early Experiments in Maithili Ghazal Grammar', 'The Maithili Ghazal in the Context of Statements', 'A Comparative Discussion of Narendraji's Maithili and Hindi Ghazals', 'When Will Ghazals in the Mood of Dushyant Kumar's Be Written in Maithili?', and 'A Maithili Ghazal That Changed the History of Maithili Song and Music'.

These earlier publications have both authorial and institutional significance. The volume is not a uniform treatise composed on a single occasion, but a collected body of ideas developed through controversy, rebuttal, and fresh encounters with texts. In such a collection, the repetition of a theme also marks the chronology of debate. For researchers, the questions become: when was a particular position taken, what objection followed, and how did the author's view change?

Videha's book collection and research index preserve a documentary record of criticism alongside the voices of Maithili ghazal writers. Such institutional preservation is particularly important in a linguistic community where journals, small-scale publications, and regional works have been unevenly accessible. These materials provide essential references for the book's historical study.

A Synthesis of Critical Achievements and Limitations

The book's first achievement is methodological firmness. The author makes examples of testing bahr and qafiya available to his readers rather than merely pronouncing vague judgements of 'good' and 'bad'. Its second achievement is an intellectual struggle for the ghazal's independent generic identity. Its third is the inclusion of language, editing, publication, history, and musical culture within ghazal criticism. Its fourth is the recognition that an expanding range of social themes can coexist with metre.

The first limitation is the uneven scope of aesthetic judgement. Examination of bahr is often elaborate, while emotional experience, shifts of meaning within couplets, imagery, symbols, creative silence, irony, and the plurality of utterance are not analysed with the same systematic attention. A second limitation is the sharp personal address employed in contemporary literary disagreements, which risks diverting attention from the arguments. A third is the frequent construction of a binary between 'metrical' and

'unmetrical', with comparatively little development of categories for intermediate experiments.

A fourth limitation concerns the evidentiary basis of historical claims. The book supplies many important leads, yet early publications, textual variants across editions, republication, and questions of alleged priority require independent bibliographical investigation. A fifth limitation is the absence of a separate theoretical framework for musical adaptation and literary textual variation. These limitations do not diminish the book's significance; they clarify possible directions for subsequent research.

Conclusion

The enduring significance of Shabd–Arth–Shakti lies not merely in its contentious voice, but in its attempt to place evaluation of the Maithili ghazal on the public plane of evidence and definition. The book makes it clear that, for its author, literary freedom is not synonymous with a lack of discipline; he regards knowledge of form as the basis of creative freedom. This idea becomes most productive when plurality of meaning, linguistic variation, and innovation in poetic experience are valued as highly as formal correctness.

The book may be regarded as an active turning point in the history of Maithili ghazal studies. It attempts to transform love of the genre into sustained examination, praise of writers into critical testing, and celebratory accounts of literary tradition into questions and answers. Its proper evaluation lies in engaging with its sharpness, testing its arguments afresh, and extending the questions that it has left unresolved.

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PART IV

Digital Archives and the Maithili Public Sphere

Rereading Maithili Literature

REVIEW 14

A History of Maithili Web Journalism

Archives, Media Transformation, and the Literary Public Sphere

Abstract

Ashish Anchinhar's A History of Maithili Web Journalism represents a distinctive tendency in modern Maithili prose, bringing the history of journalism, language technology, cultural memory, and public controversy into dialogue. Its principal concerns are Maithili's earliest presence on the Internet; the chronology of pioneering journals and websites; relations between literary and news-oriented media; developments in Mithilakshar and Unicode; the role of social media; and the history of collaborative knowledge-making. The book examines numerous claims of being ‘first’, though it sometimes itself adopts categorical language about priority. The present study treats this tension not simply as a weakness but as an active subject of historiography. Through thematic textual analysis, comparisons with available Videha material and earlier Maithili journalism, and critical consideration of different kinds of documentary evidence, it concludes that the work's exceptional significance lies in bringing together the first traces of digital Maithili, institutional contributions, and contested memories. Its ultimate historical reliability will depend upon continuing re-examination of contemporary archives.

Keywords

Maithili web journalism; digital literary history; Ashish Anchinhar; Videha; Mithilakshar; Unicode; collaborative editing; social media; source criticism; archival memory.

Introduction: The Need to Write a History of Digital Transformation

Traditional histories of Maithili literature have generally been organised around sequences of poets, books, genres, sects, and periodicals. The Internet, however, moved literary expression from the relatively fixed page to a dynamic platform. A composition was no longer merely a published object: its publication date, revision, reader responses, redistribution, translation, sound, image, and discoverability also became elements of its literary life. To understand these changing circumstances, the historian must examine not only lists of works but also the structure of the medium and its social practices.

A History of Maithili Web Journalism demonstrates the documentary possibilities of this new subject. The author places early websites, blogs, news media, journals, computer scripts, social networks, audiovisual platforms, and Wikipedia within a single overarching historical account. The work consequently does more than count websites: it attempts to answer how a language makes a place for itself in the public sphere.

The central argument of this critique is that the book's usefulness lies in the range of its assembled material and its questioning historical consciousness; its limitations appear in the vehemence of the author's voice, incomplete archives, uneven categories of sources, and criteria for deciding claims to be ‘first’. Only by holding both aspects together can its place in literary history become clear.

Structure, Development, and Authorial Purpose

At the outset, the author explains the origins of his study, earlier published articles, the process of revision, and the cooperation he seeks from readers. The preliminary material is linked to previous issues of Videha, special coverage of journalism, and his earlier writings. He dates the early public form of his project to 2017 and also describes incorporating fresh information over time. The work's chronological scope should therefore not be reduced to a single publication year: it is a documentary undertaking enlarged at different stages.

Its principal arrangement includes early technical discussion, Maithili's initial Internet presence, Internet references, a chronology of early websites, web seminars, language and literature, news, theatre and film and music, children's and other platforms, Mithilakshar and typography, social media, YouTube, and the development of Wikipedia. An opening inventory of ‘firsts’ and concluding archival evidence together form the internal framework.

Thematic classification provides a practical convenience, although a website can simultaneously function as a literary magazine, news platform, archive, and centre of language activism. Rigid categories may thus conceal the many-sided character of certain platforms. The most productive reading emerges when the thematic sections are understood as parts of an interconnected history.

Historiographical Method: Beyond Chronology to the Problem of Evidence

When establishing early appearances, the author identifies a fundamental problem: the date on which a website was created, the first publication date of the available material, and the later republication of that material do not constitute identical evidence. The possibility of backdating older blogs, the reappearance of articles on migrated platforms, and the loss of material when servers close all complicate the chronology. On this point the book raises a basic question of digital historiography.

The distinctions between kinds of evidence are not, however, always fully articulated. An author's contemporary declaration, a preserved copy of an original publication, an independent archival reference, a website's present description, and a third party's recollection possess different evidentiary values. When a claim rests only on currently available traces, it would be more appropriate to say ‘the earliest according to available evidence’. Historical conclusions gain strength from testing evidence, not from the severity of criticism directed at rivals.

In several places the author responds to rival claims through sharp satire and the language of moral judgement. This makes for engaging reading, but emotional statements must be distinguished from archival findings in historical analysis. The work thus becomes both a source for history and an example of the struggle involved in writing it.

Defining Journalism: The Shared Terrain of News, Literature, and Editing

The book rejects the restrictive view that excludes predominantly literary media from journalism. The author's argument is that news is not confined to politics or crime: literary activities, compositions, debate, editorial interventions, and exchanges with readers also participate in contemporary public communication. This reasoning has particular force in Maithili, where many early periodicals did not institutionally separate news from literature.

Yet not every literary composition automatically becomes journalism. Editorial selection, regularity, public responsibility, verification of sources, responsiveness to current events, and accountability to readers help define journalism's distinctive character. A poem in an online literary journal and that journal's report on a literary event serve different functions, though they

are related. Reading the book's inclusive perspective alongside this distinction offers a more balanced picture of modern Maithili public life.

Here the author's contribution broadens the definition of journalism, but it needs to be supplemented with separate criteria for genre, newsworthiness, editorial practice, and the effects upon readers.

Early Web Presence: From ‘Bhalsarik Gachh’ to ‘Katek Ras Bat’

Bhalsarik Gachh, Pallavmithila, Samadiya, Apan Mithila, Prakaranter, and Katek Ras Bat occupy a central place in the discussion of early Internet history. The author treats Bhalsarik Gachh as an early presence associated with 2000, links Pallavmithila to evidence from around 2003, dates the beginning of Samadiya to 2004, and associates available material from Katek Ras Bat with 2005. This sequence also reveals connections among India, Nepal, and the diaspora.

An important feature of this account is that the expressions ‘presence of Maithili’ and ‘material written in Maithili’ are sometimes treated as equivalent and sometimes distinguished. English-language websites concerned with Maithili and blogs publishing in Maithili both undoubtedly have historical significance, but they raise different questions. The former show a broader cultural presence; the latter demonstrate direct digital use of the language. Clear separation of these two axes would organise disputes over precedence more effectively.

The author's rebuttal concerning Katek Ras Bat is not merely a comment on one website: it raises the question of who has the authority to write the memory of early digital culture. The episode recalls an ideal obligation of historians, who must both credit earlier work and impartially examine adverse evidence. Read alongside the author's previously published Videha articles, the discussion becomes part of a prolonged intellectual debate.

‘Samadiya’ and the Local Public Sphere of News

The news-oriented section includes Samadiya, Esamaad, Mithila Prime, Mithila Mirror, Nav Mithila, Maithili Zindabad, Mithila Darshan, and other outlets. The account of Samadiya's founding in 2004 and later editorial changes, and Esamaad's development from early electronic issues into a news portal, illustrates the transformation of digital journalism. It is important to distinguish among founders, editors, and subsequent managers.

The social significance of this material is that news dissemination was no longer centred solely on metropolitan printing presses. Regional events, language movements, Maithili-speaking society in Nepal, local politics, education, the arts, and community disputes acquired new audiences through digital media. These platforms made Maithili not merely a language of literature but also a language of current public dialogue.

The book questions the tendency to suppress the names of collaborators and claims about credit for founding certain news organisations. Such criticism

values institutional memory. Historians must nevertheless distinguish founders, first editors, funders, technical collaborators, and later administrators through separate sources. The presence or absence of a name alone cannot justify immediate moral conclusions.

‘Videha’: E-Journal, Archive, and Parallel Literary Institution

Videha occupies a central place in the book's most extensive and influential discussions. Details of its regular fortnightly publication from 2008, literary special issues, experiments in theatre, children's literature, ghazals and translation, multilingual and multiscript material, book access, public exchange, audiovisual initiatives, and script experimentation present Videha not simply as a journal but as an integrated cultural infrastructure.

Within Videha's digital structure, publication and archiving reinforce one another. An issue of a print magazine remains in a reader's home or a library; the older material of a digital magazine can be revived through search, republication, cross-reference, and new readerships. The book rightly recognises the historical significance of this transformation. A literary institution no longer means only a building, committee, or award: it can also mean sustained collection of material and public accessibility.

Critically considered, the abundance of material about Videha is both a strength and a source of disproportion in the volume. Other websites receive brief descriptions, while many Videha initiatives are discussed extensively. Differences in source availability, long-term activity, and authorial selection may explain this imbalance. Even so, a comparative history would benefit from predetermined evaluative criteria applicable to all the platforms under study.

Literary Blogs and Generic Innovation

The section on language and literature mentions Anchinhar Akhar's ghazal-centred experiments, the community conversations of Maithil Aar Mithila, the diverse contents of E-Mithila, and other personal or institutional platforms. A particular advantage of the digital blog was that new writing no longer had to endure a long wait for magazine editors. This enabled rapid expansion of new authorship, short forms, ghazals, satire, and critical rebuttal.

Anchinhar Akhar is connected with the author's own creative work. In writing its history, he is therefore both participant and historian. These overlapping roles provide the advantage of direct experience but also raise the problem of self-evaluation. Assessment of an author's own initiative would benefit from independent reader responses, evidence of editorial continuity, analysis of the published works' techniques, and documentation of their influence on subsequent writing.

In the context of the Maithili ghazal, digital platforms were more than publication sites: they opened up questions of bahr, metre, formal organisation, and experiment. The book points to these possibilities, though

sustained analysis of the literary texts themselves is comparatively limited. The distance between the history of blogs and an aesthetic history of the ghazal remains an important field for future study.

Theatre, Film, and Music: From Text to Audiovisual Culture

The section on theatre, film, and song discusses early music blogs, film-related platforms, the Videha Maithili Theatre Festival, and musical broadcasting initiatives in Nepal. Such developments interrupt the dominance of written text in Maithili digital public life. Melody, vernacular voices, acting, performance, theatrical history, and audiences all become connected with literature.

In criticising rival claims about the ‘first portal’, the book exposes a problem in defining genres of digital media. If a blog collecting songs, a platform reviewing films, and a comprehensive entertainment portal are grouped together, questions of sequence become confused. Distinguishing ‘first song blog’, ‘first independent film platform’, and ‘first integrated entertainment portal’ would refine the conclusions.

The digital passage of music is important for literary history because oral traditions can now be recorded, heard again, and transmitted across borders. Visual culture, however, must be assessed not only by audience size but also through quality of performance, linguistic accuracy, reinvention of folk traditions, and long-term preservation.

Children's Literature, Religion, Commerce, and Specialist Platforms

The author includes experiments in children's literature such as Nena-Bhutka, commercial initiatives such as Mithila Haat, digital forms of traditional knowledge such as Maithili Patra, health-related material, and platforms offering technical information. These examples demonstrate that the Maithili Internet is not confined to writing poetry: it also serves everyday needs, learning, trade, ritual, entertainment, and vernacular knowledge.

The digital presence of children's literature does not by itself establish an independent literary world for young readers unless the age-appropriateness of the material, the interaction of images, sound, and narrative, and children's own participation are examined. The book's references to children's platforms provide necessary historical leads; literary assessment would require separate testing of narrative form, vocabulary, didactic tendencies, and imagination.

Including religious, commercial, and health platforms in the wider history of journalism is justified by the expansion of the linguistic public sphere. Yet their reliability requires standards different from those applied to literary platforms. Medical evidence for health information, consumer protection in commerce, and authenticity of textual traditions in religious material are distinct questions.

Mithilakshar, Unicode, and Technological Autonomy

The section on script technology is central to the book's significance. It assembles information on digital fonts for Tirhuta, or Mithilakshar, claims made by different developers, Unicode proposals, language typing, transliteration, and experiments in digital publishing. C. K. Raut, Gangesh Gunjan Jha, Vinay Jha, Om Vikas, and Anshuman Pandey appear in different contexts. By comparing competing chronologies, the author attempts to move beyond a simplified narrative of a single victor.

A fundamental distinction exists among 'creating a font', 'securing recognition of a standardised character encoding', and 'developing a typing tool readily usable by ordinary readers'. Producing a private font is a historical achievement, but it is not equivalent to recognition within a universal encoding standard. Unicode standardisation is the outcome of a prolonged process involving community material, technical proposals, character research, and institutional decisions. The author's evidence illuminates several different stages of this process.

The author does not regard linguistic grammar and the shape of script as unrelated; he stresses the distinctive nature of Maithili inflections and word arrangements in Tirhuta writing. This position should not be reduced to a wish merely to preserve a script. It concerns the relationship among linguistic autonomy, vernacular textual forms, and computer representation. At the same time, the historical existence of multiple scripts, divergent ways of writing inflections, and different reading traditions cannot be denied. A balance between standardisation and living linguistic plurality is essential.

Braille, Multiscript Publication, and the Right of Access

The book gives particular attention to Videha's experiments involving Tirhuta, Braille, Kaithi, Devanagari, the International Phonetic Alphabet, and other scripts. It would be wrong to see multiscript publication merely as a display of scripts; it offers possible ways to carry Maithili literature to different readerships. Braille in particular makes accessibility a central issue in literary history.

Yet the mere availability of a multiscript file is not the same as an accessible reading experience. Standardised Braille representation, compatibility with devices, textual accuracy, stable fonts, and searchable writing all form part of access rights. The book's historical account begins this discussion; subsequent criticism can investigate the practical results.

Social Media: Women's Voices, Dalit Expression, and Democratic Participation

In discussing social media, the book sees new opportunities for popular expression. Its principal observations are that Facebook helped expand women's personal voices, the presence of Dalit writers, shared performances of folk songs, the memories of diaspora communities, and regional exchange.

Here history ceases to be a mere record of technical progress and becomes a question of social representation.

The recognition of widened possibilities for women and Dalit voices is a progressive feature of the work. A readership platform emerged outside the traditional entry points controlled by periodicals, where writers could themselves become publishers and respondents. Yet ‘presence’ is not ‘equality’. Online harassment, ridicule of languages, caste prejudice, systems controlling content visibility, and unequal access to devices constrain free expression. The author's enthusiasm should be read alongside these structural questions.

Social media do not automatically guarantee democracy: some voices may be amplified while others are suppressed. The book indicates this tension, but independent literary readings of women's writing, the works of Dalit authors, and comparative studies of community experience remain tasks for future research.

The Illusions of Facebook Reach, Responses, and Popularity

The book criticises misconceptions surrounding ‘likes’, reach, promotion, and paid distribution. This observation matters because digital visibility does not prove literary value. Public interest in news, poetic beauty, authorial labour, and the reliability of historical facts cannot be established by the number of audience reactions.

The internal rules of digital platforms change with time, however. Their mechanisms of reach, group behaviour, and promotion at a particular moment should not be taken as permanent laws. The relevant passages are better read as evidence of digital experience in a particular period, not as timeless technical prescriptions. This distinction does not lessen the book's historical usefulness; it situates it properly.

Mobile Applications and the Everyday Use of Language

The material on applications lists early initiatives in dictionaries, songs, calendars, marriage, news, religious texts, health, and other fields. Such inventories are useful to digital linguistic history because they show the transition from websites to mobile devices. Language tools available in people's hands create new relationships among education, information, and cultural identity.

The date an application first appears and its long-term usefulness are different matters. An application may be released but never updated, lose its linguistic content, or become technically unusable. These differences must be recognised. To assess the living history of these initiatives, evidence is needed not only of release dates but also of actual usage, maintenance, security, and public reach.

YouTube: Creating a Channel and First Publishing Maithili Material

In the YouTube section, the author distinguishes the date on which a channel was created from the date Maithili material first appeared on it. References to 'vijay7701', Gajendra Thakur's channel, Rajni Pallavi's performances, and numerous later channels are useful in this regard. The date a channel was opened does not in itself establish the publication history of Maithili literature or music: this is one of the book's important methodological observations.

YouTube has opened up new economic possibilities for singing in Maithili, performance before the camera, fresh presentations of folk songs, and spontaneous expression in regional speech. The author attends to the emerging use of strongly vernacular language. Further literary-historical study of these phenomena would require analyses of pronunciation, subtitles, audiences, gender representation, creative rights, and the visual language of performance.

Older material may be deleted; channel names may change; and audiovisual content may be reuploaded. The standards used to verify chronology must therefore be multilayered here as well. The author's investigation supplies an initial map of this history, not a final definitive register.

Maithili Wikipedia: A History of Collective Labour

The author discusses the roles of several individuals in the development of Maithili Wikipedia, from its initial initiatives to recognition in 2014. References to Gajendra Thakur, Umesh Mandal, Rajesh Ranjan, Biplab Anand, and other contributors reveal a process that was not the work of one person but the combined outcome of requests, translation, editing, technical dialogue, and community participation.

Disputes over credit cannot be resolved simply by asking 'Who spoke first?' Proposing a project, preparing required material, contributing during its testing phase, facilitating approval through discussions, taking initial administrative responsibility, and continuing to write are distinct kinds of work. The author identifies some of these levels, but impartial history requires them all to be organised with equal conceptual clarity.

The Wikipedia discussion opens up a serious theoretical possibility in the book: a language is not merely the achievement of a single institution but the collective practice of producing public knowledge. The author's insistence on distinguishing digital volunteer activity from formally institutionalised projects is also noteworthy. Nevertheless, the presence or absence of remuneration does not itself determine the quality of work or its historical authenticity.

The Archival Meaning of the Appendix: From Messages of Welcome to Cultural Memory

The final part collects congratulations, responses, and contemporary references received when Videha began publishing. Such material cannot simply be dismissed as testimonials. These messages illuminate contemporary expectations of a Maithili e-journal, enthusiasm for a new medium, attachment to the language, and relationships between writers and readers.

Messages of welcome, however, constitute a particular kind of critical evidence. They reveal contemporary acceptance and perception; they do not independently verify every achievement of the project. Praise for someone's dedicated labour is not decisive historical proof of being 'first'. The appendix's real documentary value becomes clearer when read with this limitation in mind.

Narrative Style: First Person, Rebuttal, and the Energy of Prose

The language of the book lies between scholarly discussion and public debate. The author does not conceal his 'I': he speaks directly to readers, anticipates objections, tests doubts, and answers rival claims. His prose conveys the energy of events and the labour of investigation. This is a living form, distinct from lifeless academicism.

The literary strength of the style lies in its dialogic nature, narrative turns, and intellectual alertness. The search for early websites becomes a kind of investigative narrative. Names, dates, opposing declarations, and archival traces are presented in sequence; readers participate in the decisive moments of the historical inquiry. This dramatic dimension of the prose deserves recognition as a literary quality.

For research to remain disciplined, however, its language should distinguish conjecture, recollection, interpretation, and verified fact. Where criticism becomes personal sarcasm, the force of facts may be obscured. A future revision would gain credibility by retaining the sharpness of its questions while reducing judgements directed at individuals.

A Comparative Perspective on Literary History: From Print Journalism to the Digital Magazine

Earlier Maithili journalism developed through literary periodicals, editorial movements, social consciousness, and public advocacy for the language. The author himself mentions Chandranath Mishra 'Amar's' history of journalism; the available Videha book catalogue also lists Dr Yoganand Jha's A Hundred Years of Maithili Journalism. Older magazines such as Maithil Hit Sadhan and Mithila Mihir provide important cultural references within this historical tradition.

In print journalism, publication times are marked by comparatively stable issues; in digital media, material can be revised, removed, relocated, and

republished. Editorial authority is centralised in print journals, whereas blogs and social networks connect writers directly with readers. Preserving older print magazines depended on the conservation of paper, while the protection of digital archives depends on servers, code, character encoding, ownership, and regular migration.

The comparison demonstrates that the method of writing the history of modern journalism has changed. Yet the emergence of digital media does not render older editorial principles irrelevant. Fact-checking, language editing, space for diverse opinions, institutional accountability, and readers' trust remain fundamental journalistic values. The book stands at the meeting point of older and newer traditions.

The Parallel History of Maithili Literature and the Digital Public Sphere

One distinctive feature of digital Maithili is that writers can reach readers outside established publishing institutions, city-centred editorial structures, and recognition based on awards. The expansion of Videha and other blogs illustrates this historical possibility. Digital spaces give new visibility to authors comparatively neglected by traditional literary history, vernacular voices, minor genres, and experimental literature.

In this context, 'parallel' means more than opposition to established institutions: it means widening the evidentiary basis of history. New sources have historical value when they revise older conclusions; merely contradicting the mainstream does not, by itself, constitute evidence. A parallel history becomes most credible when it can also critically examine the platforms, writers, and groups it favours.

Technology-related articles already published in Videha, controversies over the early history of the web in 2017, articles from 2019 and 2021, and a book review from 2023 show that study of the subject has developed continuously. Rather than treating a single volume as a final history, it is therefore more appropriate to use it to develop a systematic tradition of sources for further inquiry.

Principal Achievements of the Book

The book's first achievement is the independent formulation of a neglected historical subject. Its second is the extensive collection of the names, dates, roles, and available evidence concerning early digital platforms. Its third is to place literary and news-oriented media within a shared digital public sphere. Its fourth is to connect Mithilakshar, Unicode, and language accessibility with the history of journalism. Its fifth is to make the participation of women, Dalits, the diaspora, and younger generations part of the history of the language.

The author's questioning disposition is additionally noteworthy. Refusing to accept established claims merely on the basis of reputation is essential to

research. In many places the book generates new questions instead of supplying definitive answers; from a scholarly standpoint, this is itself an important contribution.

Limitations and Possibilities for Revision

The first limitation is insufficient clarity in classifying the many claims to have been ‘first’. Second, despite the abundance of information, consistent comparative criteria for user groups, effects on readers, editorial policies, and literary quality remain underdeveloped. Third, several websites are discussed according to their present availability; silence caused by missing archives cannot be taken as proof that something never existed.

The fourth limitation is the author's mixed position as both independent witness and participant. Fifth, materials added at different times produce a mixture of the historical past, the present contemporary with the earlier writing, and a revised present. Connecting each historical assertion with the period in which its information was gathered would increase reliability. Sixth, technical terminology sometimes conflates levels that should be distinguished: medium, platform, font, encoding, and application.

The purpose of these criticisms is not to undervalue the labour behind the work, but to give it greater durability. With clearer dates, source types, evidence for original claims, grounds for competing claims, and levels of confidence in conclusions, the volume has the potential to become a lasting reference work for the subject.

Conclusion: From Collection to History, from History to Criticism

A History of Maithili Web Journalism is a notable, archive-oriented work of modern Maithili prose. Its subject is not simply the expansion of journalism but the birth of a new public life for the language. From Bhalsarik Gachh and early blogs to Videha's fortnightly e-journal; from computer experiments with Mithilakshar to collective knowledge production on Wikipedia; from the digital life of folk songs to dissenting voices on social media—the author records an extensive cultural movement.

The work's most important message is that history is not merely the art of putting available evidence in order: it also demands a fair examination of attribution, presence, silence, memory, and controversy. The question of ‘priority’ that the book raises must be applied to its own method as well. It is precisely here that its critical possibilities are richest. The author's argumentative energy and labour of documentary collection make the work distinctive; more explicit categories of evidence, comparative standards, and a dialogic idiom could make it still more authoritative.

Ultimately, this book deserves to be regarded not as a completed story but as a foundational construction for the early history of digital Maithili. Its actual historical contribution will become clearer as future research considers literary

content, editorial history, technical archives, public access, and literary influence together.

Textual Basis and the Limits of Quotation

The present study takes the sequence of events, titles, names, and thematic details in the available original text as its basis. Where the exact wording of a person's statement could not be established beyond doubt, the argument has been critically discussed in substance instead of offering a purported verbatim quotation. The book's account of itself, its self-declared priorities, and its claims against other platforms are treated as parts of the author's historical perspective, not as independently and conclusively established facts. Acknowledging these limits preserves both the work's actual achievements and the legitimate scope of criticism.

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VIDEHA · MAITHILI LITERATURE

PART II / TOME IX

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Theatre, Poetics and Literary Criticism

Gajendra Thakur · English translations from original Maithili by the author himself · Videha

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STUDY 08 / NIT NAVAL

Bechan Thakur

01 / 06

Navghar

Folk Society, Reform, and Theatrical Resistance

The Character of the Collection of Plays

Navghar is a collection of four one-act plays by Bechan Thakur. Published by Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali (Supaul), it contains *Nisha Mukti*, *Barham Baba*, *Ghoghvali Kaniya*, and *Rasun Piyoj*. The available edition contains conflicting references to 2018 and 2017; the edition chronology therefore calls for caution.

Each of the collection's four one-act plays constructs its own social situation. *Nisha Mukti* and *Ghoghvali Kaniya* unfold across five scenes each, whereas *Barham Baba* and *Rasun Piyoj* are based on comparatively extended single scenes. This distinction affects their plots, character development, centres of conflict, and dramatic outcomes.

The forms of the titles also deserve attention. The original printing gives *Nisha*, *Barham*, *Ghoghvali*, and *Rasun Piyoj*. These vernacular choices are bound up with the works' sounds, the social positions of their characters, and their humour. In critical prose, explanatory expressions equivalent to 'freedom from addiction', 'the veil', and 'garlic and onions' may be used where necessary; replacing the original titles with such synonyms, however, would compromise textual fidelity.

The Conceptual Basis of the Study: Text, Stage, and Society

To treat Maithili theatre solely as a literature of written dialogue would obscure the distinctiveness of Bechan Thakur's dramatic endeavour. His texts contain the practices of the stage: entrances and exits, slogans shouted in unison, songs, physical actions, preparations for public meetings, and gestures that directly address the audience. The plays are therefore examined here on two levels: the written scenes encountered by readers and the potential performances in which actors' timing, pauses, stage design, and audience responses may transform their meanings.

Videha's *A Complete Critical Appreciation of Bechan Thakur* raises questions of parallel theatre, social representation, and Thakur's dramatic practice. That critical background is useful here, but it would be inappropriate to impose predetermined activist conclusions on every episode of *Navghar*.

Where the play itself offers concrete means of change, its achievement should be assessed; where characters lose their complexity and become vehicles for pronouncements, its limitations must also be acknowledged. Questions concerning rasa, dialogue, folk character, and social representation in Videha's body of dramatic criticism serve as comparative instruments in this discussion.

This study does not automatically treat dialogue in a play as factual evidence concerning historical events, the success rates of government announcements, or actual audience numbers at performances. What a character says is, in the first instance, a statement within the dramatic world; its external historical verification is a separate matter. Maintaining this distinction is an elementary precaution of textual criticism.

Nisha Mukti: Intoxication, Violence, Popular Education, and Collective Resolve

Scene One: From Family Affection to Insecurity

The first scene opens in Shankar's home. Through the presence of Sunena, Shanti, Chani, Sugar, and Kharban, domestic conversation, and children's play, the narrative initially establishes an ordinary family situation. An objective crisis gradually enters beneath this calm surface. Children's games, the struggle to provide food, the intimacy of a familiar home, and the effects of intoxication are placed alongside one another. In the speech of some characters, violent habits become normalised; this dramatic contrast intensifies the impending crisis.

Scene Two: The Road, the Railway Journey, and the Public Consequences

Between the two scenes, the action moves from the home into the public sphere. Shankar and Kharban's journey outside, the arrival of the student characters Rajiv and Raushan with Meena, the presence of the police, and news of an accident suggest that the social cost of an individual's addiction is not confined to the family threshold. The event does not seem to be fully developed as a visible action onstage; much of it reaches the audience through characters' accounts. The subject consequently expands rapidly, but the dramatic intimacy of lived experience sometimes gives way to informational dialogue.

Scene Three: The Political Language of Prohibition and Moral Reasoning

The third scene is the principal site of public debate. In the conversations of the police characters Kedar Singh and Badri Singh, Shankar, and Kharban, government policy, personal harm, crime, and social conduct are brought into relation. An important turning point occurs when the discussion goes beyond punishment to consider a person's capacity for self-restraint. Badri Singh's statement makes self-control a measure of humanity.

> 'The more the mind remains under control, the richer we shall be in humanity.' (Badri Singh)

This sentence signifies not merely the rejection of addiction but also the ethical importance of self-determination. Yet the idealistic formulation gives insufficient scope to the structural questions of exploitation, unemployment, and medical assistance. The police officer's coherent social counsel can become an effective speech onstage, but the play engages only to a limited extent with arguments against it.

Scene Four: Children's Intervention in a Domestic Crisis

The fourth scene returns to Shankar's home. The child characters, domestic tensions, and emotional appeals to give up drinking create an immediate dramatic problem. Here children are not simply helpless victims: at several points they ask questions and influence decisions. In this respect, the scene could be especially effective for younger audiences. Nevertheless, a sensitive staging of fear, injury, and familial trauma is indispensable when addressing children.

Scene Five: School, Song, and Collective Discipline

The concluding scene turns towards an educational institution and a public-awareness event. Teachers, students, songs, slogans, collective recitation, and public praise make the play's social message explicit. The crisis that had silently spread inside the home has now become a collective programme onstage. Song functions here as a means of popular education that fixes the message in the audience's memory; however, the large cast and repeated slogans demand careful timing in an actual performance.

The distinctive feature of *Nisha Mukti* is its transition from domestic drama to public theatre. Its limitation is that the final scene is so strongly shaped by the promotional language of an educational campaign that the contradictions of social reality do not fully develop into dramatic conflict. Children's participation increases its potential for young audiences; rather than describing it as an exclusively children's play, it would be more accurate to call it 'a one-act play of social awareness suitable for both young and adult audiences'.

Barham Baba: Faith, Tradition, and the Right to Question

Establishing Place and Situation

Barham Baba is brief in length but sharp in its central idea. The shrine of Barham Baba, ritual objects, a religious gathering of women and men, and Bauku's devotion initially establish a familiar rural religious setting. Budhan's arrival reinforces inherited belief; Phulo gradually begins to question the conditions attached to that belief. The issue is thus not a wholesale denial of religion's existence but the ethical consequences of particular social practices.

The Authority of Class and Caste Within Faith

The disagreement between Bauku and Phulo turns on who may worship, who may perform worship, in whose name exclusion may be practised, and how social humiliation can be presented as a deity's command. The repetition

of 'Jai Ganga' and Phulo's counter-questions create two dramatic voices: on one side, the spontaneous devotion of faith; on the other, an insistence that faith must justify itself through questioning. To label Phulo's reasoning mere atheism would be mistaken; her objection defends human dignity.

Phulo's Objection and the Final Acceptance

Phulo does not express her argument in the abstract language of philosophical debate. She speaks through concrete experiences of food, endurance, dignity, her own circumstances, and humanity. One of her sentences forms the emotional centre of the entire work.

> 'I hunger for love and respect.' (Phulo)

In this line, 'faith' is not destroyed; rather, the object of reverence is redefined. At the end, Bauku promises to think again, opening the way to reconsider the arrangements for worship. The play derives its force here from an ethical answer rather than violent retaliation. Its limitation is equally clear: the institutional caste structure underlying Phulo's protest is not explored, and the final solution depends heavily on a character's individual change of heart.

In theatrical terms, the play's few characters, single location, and explicit ideological conflict may make it suitable for street theatre, senior school groups, and small theatre companies. Its questioning spirit is important for young readers, but a presenter would need to explain the implications of socio-religious hierarchy in a context-sensitive way.

Ghoghvali Kaniya: From Domestic Life to Social Reconstruction

Ghoghvali Kaniya is the most extensive one-act play in *Navghar*. To regard it merely as a play opposing the veil would diminish the work's actual range. Its narrative encompasses family disintegration, rights over food and money, the protection of family members' lives, education, rural reform, women's agency, and collective decision-making at the panchayat level. The veil in the title initially signifies society's control over a woman's private life; her subsequent entry into the full range of social decision-making reverses that symbol.

Scene One: Children, Daughters-in-Law, and Old Age

The scene opens with the family circumstances of Satan and his wife Lalita. Their sons Jitan and Pardeshi, their daughters-in-law Ramdai and Rupvati, the respected community figure Ramrup, and other members of the family debate the division of property, respect for elderly people, and independent living. The ageing body and the accumulated authority of the ageing mind confront one another. This is not simply a struggle between sons and father: it is a dispute over the definition of 'home'. Does a home mean merely living together, or does it require equal respect and a just share for all?

With Rupvati's entrance, an independent female voice in decision-making becomes prominent. She refuses the obligation to accept established family decisions and asks whose interests those decisions serve. How equally are the

recognition, labour, and service of every family member valued? This question moves the first scene beyond ordinary domestic quarrelling towards the consideration of social ethics. Rupvati's initiative becomes the principal force driving the story forward.

Scene Two: From Compassion to a Written Agreement

The second scene displays the courage to translate family relationships into practical rules. In the presence of Vishnudev, Ramprasad, Satan, and Pardeshi, the relatives consider an extensive proposal. The printed proposal contains twenty-two points, addressing fields and farmland, housing, support for elderly parents, mutual visits, financial arrangements, personal service, regular care, and assistance in times of crisis. A written agreement becomes a concrete instrument of social reform.

> 'Let the two brothers take half the fields and farmland each.' (First clause of the agreement)

The advantage of this list within the narrative is that moral expectations acquire the explicit language of rights and responsibilities. Dramaturgically, however, reading out twenty-two points without interruption presents a serious problem: the plot stops, and the stage can begin to resemble the minutes of a meeting. As a written text, the list creates documentary realism; in performance, the clauses would need to be brought alive through visual groupings, conflicting positions, and reactions.

After the agreement, the characters' language of acceptance becomes central.

> 'I have no objection. I agree.' (Jitan)

Through this method of obtaining consent, the play imagines a miniature domestic form of deliberative democracy. Yet in actual life the division of land and care of elderly people are not resolved by agreement alone. The play's treatment of law, registration, compliance with obligations, and the balance of power is extremely limited. This limitation should be understood not as the historical failure of the text but as a feature of its utopian reformist character.

Scene Three: Children's Imagination, Education, and the Right to Play

In the third scene, relationships between generations change through Jitan, Ramdai, Satan, Lalita, and Shashi. Particular emphasis falls on children's play, free time, thirst for knowledge, artistic creation, and freedom of expression. Between the courtyard, school, conversation, and adults' instructions, the child's mind seeks a place of its own. This section connects the collection most concretely with questions of children's literature.

Satan warns against coercion in matters of children's play and education. He supports the possibility of developing knowledge without repression. The scene suggests that it is wrong to regard a child merely as the prototype of a future wage-earning adult: curiosity, imagination, and independent experience in the present are valuable in themselves.

As the play's discussion of education expands, however, the dialogue sometimes becomes a speech dominated by reasoning. When children ask questions themselves, the scene comes alive; when adult characters continually deliver lessons on their behalf, the child's independent dramatic voice weakens. This distinction requires particular attention in school performances.

Scene Four: A New Female Voice and the Meaning of Home

The fourth scene begins with a private conversation between Pardeshi and Rupvati. Rupvati raises questions about contemporary ways of life, her public identity, respect for domestic work, and unthinking household traditions. She is unwilling to accept an existence restricted to the role of an invisible housewife.

> 'I am no ordinary woman.' (Rupvati)

It would be a mistake to dismiss this assertion of self-worth as mere vanity. It demands the right to an identity. Nonetheless, a critical question arises: does Rupvati's modernity sometimes become confined to signs of clothing, appearance, and social display? The fact that her dramatic challenge is linked to concrete economic and political activity helps counterbalance this potential weakness.

The fourth scene continues to debate domestic rights, the condition of parents-in-law, the family's public image, and women's agency. The play does not offer a convenient moral division between the nuclear and joint family. It allows both to be criticised according to standards of respect, justice, and responsibility. Although some characters undergo psychological change with remarkable speed, the energy of Rupvati's dissent sustains the narrative's vitality.

Scene Five: The Panchayat, Women's Participation, and Public Acceptance

The fifth scene is a collective meeting held in the panchayat building. Matters previously suppressed within the home—family discord, women's participation, and care for the elderly—become subjects of public discussion. The gathering of the sarpanch, Ramprasad, Vishnudev, Rupvati, Pardeshi, and others places the play's ethical objective before society.

Seen as a whole, the work moves from private suffering towards public accountability. Yet in the fifth scene, dramatic conflict is largely absorbed into a meeting for decisions and their endorsement. At times, a succession of recommendations takes precedence over the characters' autonomous voices. This limitation does not invalidate the play's social commitment; it simply shows that accomplishing reform and making drama are not the same thing.

The central importance of *Ghoghvali Kaniya* is its vision of a *navghar*, a 'new home', where women, children, and elderly people enjoy rights together with their dignity. The veil of the title symbolises the darkness within the household; Rupvati's activity offers its counter-reading. To strengthen the work dramatically, there is scope to condense the twenty-two-point

agreement, lengthy sermons, and numerous character appearances, making interpersonal conflict more embodied and action-driven.

Rasun Piyoj: Inflation, Ridicule, and the Power to Name

The First Debate: From Market Prices to Human Worth

In the fourth one-act play, Raman, Suman, Aman, and Pavan are playing cards. The onlookers Feku, Kailu, Gannu, and Chullai are also present. Feku interrupts the easy entertainment of this opening scene by speaking of rising market prices. The increased cost of garlic and onions serves as an ordinary vernacular measure of economic reality.

> 'Garlic used to cost twenty rupees a kilo; now it has risen to eighty.' (Feku)

Yet words that initially referred to the price of food gradually become an insulting form of address for Feku. Through this transition, the play attacks nicknaming, class contempt, and the violence of collective laughter. A place for idle conversation becomes a stage: when laughter becomes public, it can deprive a person of dignity.

The Structure of Collective Laughter

> The phonetic repetition of 'rasun-piyoj' generates comedy. The characters turn the name into a chant; laughter intensifies, as does Feku's anger. The scene discloses the double nature of humour: laughter can bring people together, but it can also become a weapon of unjust collective action. At the centre of the subject is the legitimacy of the so-called joke: whose suffering does a particular kind of laughter produce?

Feku's assertion of self-respect constitutes the heart of the play.

> 'I am no less than anyone else.' (Feku)

This statement should not be treated as evidence for an entire history of caste or economic class; what is clear is that an ordinary person confronting humiliation declares his equality. His personal resistance to ridicule becomes a test of the moral consciousness of the surrounding community.

Social Judgement and the Ending of the Satire

In the latter part, intervention by neighbours and panchayat figures transforms a private quarrel into a public problem. Rather than developing a collective rejection of the legitimacy of mockery, the play sometimes suggests accepting the nickname as a common social habit. The ending thus poses a moral dilemma: does making a derogatory form of address widespread eliminate the insult, or normalise the social power of humiliation?

On the final page, after a decision has been reached, Feku's name is once again spoken by the crowd. The scene can be read as a happy ending of reconciliation through easy banter; in a critical rereading, however, the victim's consent becomes much more important. The work gains richness if collective laughter is treated not as a moral conclusion but as an unresolved dramatic conflict.

Rasun Piyoj is theatrically effective because of its minimal stage requirements, natural entrances, everyday speech, and recurring nickname. Some long speeches and an externally supplied moral resolution somewhat weaken its satire. For children and adolescents, the text can open dramatic discussion about verbal violence, the limits of teasing one's peers, and self-respect. Without thoughtful discussion from the humiliated character's perspective, however, the laughter onstage may have the opposite effect.

An Interrelated Literary Critique of All Four One-Act Plays

Movements Between Home, Society, and the Public Assembly

All four plays share a common movement: an incident begins in the home or a familiar circle, while its final meaning is determined in public society. In *Nisha Mukti*, a family's addiction becomes a social campaign; in *Barham Baba*, private faith becomes a question of social justice; in *Ghoghvali Kaniya*, a domestic settlement is made public at the panchayat; and in *Rasun Piyoj*, joking among companions and neighbours becomes a dispute before a public assembly. The assembly is both an institution for resolving problems and a possible site of coercion. The strength of the author's social drama lies in this staging of collective life.

Questioning Characters Versus Characters Who Announce Decisions

Where Phulo, Rupvati, or the child characters ask questions, the dialogue contains genuine dramatic energy. Where police officers, community representatives, or panchayat leaders announce predetermined conclusions, the drama's natural opposition contracts. The greatest dramatic tension in the writer's method lies between these two tendencies: the open process of democratic questioning and the closed result of reformist proclamation.

Vernacular Speech, Repetition, and Phonetic Rhythm

Bechan Thakur's characters speak the unpretentious language of their communities. Devotional utterances in *Barham Baba*, awareness songs in *Nisha Mukti*, familial forms of address in *Ghoghvali Kaniya*, and repeated nicknames in *Rasun Piyoj* produce distinct aural identities. In this language, voices shaped by experience matter more than polished classical uniformity. Standardising vernacular words would diminish the theatrical rhythm and social implications of many passages.

The Agency of Female Characters and the Limits of Representation

Phulo and Rupvati provide ideological counter-positions; Sunena, Lalita, and other female characters participate in the processes of domestic life, nurture, and change. Their presence is not merely an emotional backdrop. Yet the question of women's rights can acquire sufficient depth only when these characters articulate their own disagreements, economic conditions, and social risks. The reformist consensus in *Ghoghvali Kaniya* points in this direction, but in many places it still awaits the endorsement of decisions made by men.

Reformist Hope and the Unresolved Complexities of Life

The collection's happy endings reveal the author's commitment to social reform. Nonetheless, alcohol addiction, caste exclusion, the rights of older people, women's autonomy, and social ridicule are problems that cannot be fully resolved by a single speech, written promise, or panchayat ruling. The distance between the play's ethical desire and the difficulties of social processes should remain a central criterion of criticism. Recognising that distance does not diminish the author's purpose; rather, it grounds the work's historical and creative significance in reality.

The Place of *Navghar* in the History of Maithili Children's Literature: A Comparative Study

Writing a history of children's literature requires an initial distinction between oral literature for infants and modern written drama for children. In Videha, Phulchandra Jha 'Praveen's' *Maithili Shishu Lok Sahitya* (issue 50, 2010) illuminates traditions of lullabies, games, oral expression, and memories transmitted across generations. *Navghar*'s relation to this background does not establish direct imitation of a source, but rather a shared terrain of popular voices and audience participation. Songs and collective utterances in modern social one-act plays recall the dramatic potential of an older oral tradition.

Yoganand Jha's *Maithili Bal-Lokkatha: Sthiti a Apeksha* (Videha, issue 76, 2011) and Ramesh Ranjan's article identified by the title *Maithili Balnatak Sima Vistar Karait—Chauari* (issue 126, 2013) brought children's stories and children's drama into view as distinct critical subjects in the history of Videha's debates on children's literature. Drama is expected to do more than teach lessons; it should give meaningful stage space to children's questions, playfulness, independent decisions, and imaginative perspectives. The four plays in *Navghar* yield different evaluations when examined against this standard.

The child characters at the beginning of *Nisha Mukti* and its final school event are useful for young audiences, but the emotional intensity of a railway accident and suffering associated with addiction requires adaptation according to age. *Barham Baba* can help cultivate the ability to question if its dialogue is presented within a framework of social respect. The child-centred educational thought of the third scene of *Ghoghvali Kaniya* has particular value for young readers, whereas the long property disputes and panchayat decisions in the remaining scenes may be remote from younger children's immediate experience. *Rasun Piyoj* is relevant to adolescent concerns with collective laughter, nicknames, and humiliation, provided that its presentation does not obscure the victim's suffering.

Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra (2026), published in Videha, discusses the importance of children's agency, folk memory, social representation, and linguistic formation in the evaluation of children's

narratives. While retaining the generic distinction between novels and plays, these criteria can help us examine *Navghar*: how active are its characters? Does its teaching arise from within the story, or is it imposed from outside? Are children entitled to make decisions, or do they merely listen to adults? These questions have productive consequences for evaluating the plays.

Naty-Navagraha (Videha, issue 447, 2026) offers useful observations on the distinction between children's and adult drama, playfulness in dialogue, direct participation, and thought-provoking stage arrangements. By comparison, the predominant tendency of *Navghar* is towards adult one-act drama concerned with social problems, although particular scenes contain abundant material suitable for theatre education among children and adolescents. Its appropriate literary-historical designation is therefore a collection of social one-act plays containing meaningful seeds of experimentation in children's theatre, rather than, without evidence, an original model of exclusively children's drama.

Chronology also demands restraint. The available essays on children's literature in Videha document debates in 2010, 2011, and 2013, whereas the available edition pages of *Navghar* bear both 2017 and 2018. This is insufficient to claim that the work was the 'first' Maithili children's play, the first experiment, or a definitive point of origin. The emergence of a genre and the publication of a particular collection require separate kinds of evidence in literary history.

Theatrical Potential: Performance, Audiences, and Adaptation

Vernacular language is the principal scenic resource of *Navghar*. *Barham Baba* and *Rasun Piyoj* could be staged with limited resources: the first needs a symbolic shrine and ritual objects; the second, a place for playing cards, entrances and exits, and the rhythm of laughter. Refining the rhythm of dialogue in these two plays would sharpen their ideas.

Nisha Mukti requires stage time and resources for changes of location, the railway-related narrative, police entrances, the school group, and songs and slogans. The real challenge is balancing a vivid presentation of tragic events against the declarative ending. In ensemble performance, the safety of children, symbolic treatment of violent incidents, and preservation of the dignity of people suffering from addiction should be priorities.

The five scenes and numerous speaking characters of *Ghoghvali Kaniya* would require editing for a short production. The twenty-two-point agreement could be made visible through bodily expression, signatures on paper, conflicts of interest, and silent reactions. Yet no dialogue should be removed from quotation of the original or a research-based reading; stage adaptation is a distinct creative undertaking, separate from the source text.

If children perform these works, scenes should be selected according to age group. For children aged ten to fourteen, the dispute over naming in *Rasun Piyoj*, the counter-questions in *Barham Baba*, and the educational section of

Ghoghvali Kaniya seem more workable. This age recommendation is a critical proposal for practical staging, not a historical fact. Asking the audience after each scene, 'What would you have done?', could turn the play's conclusion away from one-sided instruction towards collective deliberation.

Achievements, Contradictions, and Critical Judgement

Navghar's first achievement is its choice of social situations. The author connects ordinary domestic incidents—meals, children's play, responsibilities among relatives, and jokes about nicknames—to wider questions of rights. Its second achievement is the continuity of vernacular language. A third is its granting of dramatic authority to question to characters such as Phulo and Rupvati. A fourth is the skill with which social assemblies, folk songs, and crowds become part of the narrative structure.

Its chief limitations include the one-dimensionality of certain characters, repeated exposition of the same idea, lengthy readings of agreements, sudden consensus, and excessively rapid resolution of questions of justice. A clear ethical position is not a defect in reformist drama; it becomes one when opponents cease to embody social circumstances and remain mere symbols of ignorance, reducing the complexity of conflict. This problem occurs at several points in the collection.

The limits of folk humour require special consideration. In *Rasun Piyoj*, it is not enough to see laughter solely as creative energy; one must also recognise how thoroughly a person can be humiliated through naming. Similarly, *Barham Baba* turns social contempt concealed behind religious devotion into its subject. Taken together, these works yield a larger ethical principle: whether in the name of religion or in the name of a joke, violations of personal dignity should not be treated as normal.

The study therefore regards *Navghar* as an important example of the Maithili social one-act play, marked by a strong tendency towards parallel theatrical thought and faith in community education. Its excellence lies in the living questions of dialogue, scenes of folk social life, and characters' demands for self-respect; its weakness lies in speeches that predetermine solutions. It is precisely this tension that makes the collection worthy of criticism.

Conclusion

Taken together, the four plays in Bechan Thakur's *Navghar* disclose four problems in the ethical life of modern Mithila. *Nisha Mukti* moves from the private and public harms of lack of restraint to popular education; *Barham Baba* measures faith against human equality; *Ghoghvali Kaniya* seeks a new settlement between domestic authority and social justice; and *Rasun Piyoj* questions the humiliation concealed within collective laughter. These works are not merely declarations of reform: they offer many rich possibilities for dramatic debate.

From the perspective of children's literature, the collection occupies a mixed position. Some scenes directly present children's experiences and participation; others centre on adult social institutions and familial responsibilities. Acknowledging this difference is a matter of fidelity to genre. The collection's contribution to the history of Maithili one-act drama lies in the meeting of vernacular language, social justice, and the collective nature of the stage. When documentation of its performances, textual variants, contemporary reviews, and audience experiences becomes available, these conclusions can be examined more specifically.

Selected Voices from the Dialogue

In these brief passages of dialogue, the characters' original voices and dramatic circumstances find particularly forceful expression.

• *Nisha Mukti* — Badri Singh: 'The more the mind remains under control, the richer we shall be in humanity.'

• *Barham Baba* — Phulo: 'I hunger for love and respect.'

• *Ghoghvali Kaniya* — first clause of the agreement: 'Let the two brothers take half the fields and farmland each.'

• *Ghoghvali Kaniya* — Jitan: 'I have no objection. I agree.'

• *Ghoghvali Kaniya* — Rupvati: 'I am no ordinary woman.'

• *Rasun Piyoj* — Feku: 'Garlic used to cost twenty rupees a kilo; now it has risen to eighty.'

• *Rasun Piyoj* — Feku: 'I am no less than anyone else.'

02 / 06

Betik Apman and Chhinar Devi

Theatre Against Discrimination Against Daughters, Dowry, and Superstition

Introducing the Subject: Literature, Social Problems, and the Responsibility of Theatre

The study of Maithili drama is often confined to printed works and the history of well-known theatre institutions. Regular performances at village level, the participation of male and female students, public productions during Saraswati Puja, and theatrical activity undertaken with limited resources deserve equal importance in literary history. The distinctiveness of Bechan Thakur's collection lies not merely in his construction of plots opposing two social evils. It also lies in his bringing into the plays the shared moral world of rural families, neighbourhoods, panchayats, marriage relations and kinship, ritual healers, priests, and spectators while portraying these problems.

These plays are reformist in outlook, but theirs is not a one-dimensional reformism. Characters sometimes contradict themselves in their own speech; when social values change, old greed assumes a new disguise; and reasoning enters even under the cover of religion. Thus the author's declared message is not identical to the wider meaning generated by the dramatic work. The purpose of this review is neither to turn the author's good intentions into unquestioning praise nor to belittle his community-based theatrical practice on account of inconsistencies in staging. Rather, it is to examine artistic achievements and critical limitations in the light of evidence present in the texts.

The Book and Its Theatrical Context

Betik Apman a Chhinar Devi is a collection of two social plays by Bechan Thakur. The book, published by Shruti Prakashan, includes an introduction by Ashish Anchinhar and the author's own statement, introducing readers to the social questions and rural theatrical experience associated with the work.

The publication details identify 2010 as the year of the first edition, while the introduction refers to the 2011 census. This chronological discrepancy makes it advisable to treat the edition date cautiously.

In his statement, the author explains that his concern in writing *Betik Apman* was the inferior status assigned to daughters, dowry, and the destruction of female foetuses; *Chhinar Devi* grew out of experiences of hatred and hostility developing within family relationships under the influence of superstition. He states that he has staged his works every year during Saraswati Puja since 2002 and that most performances have been given by female students. This personal testimony may be regarded as important evidence of the author's theatrical experience; in the absence of independent performance records, however, it would be inappropriate to draw definite statistical conclusions about the number or impact of these productions.

In his introduction, Ashish Anchinhar interprets *Chhinar Devi* as a play opposing superstition and draws a relationship of question and answer with Harimohan Jha's satirical tradition. In the case of *Betik Apman*, he considers the preference for sons in Mithila and Haryana to be comparable. The foreword is not merely an encomium to the author; it also expects Maithili theatre of its time to intervene more directly in social matters. It is important to keep the historical and social claims in the foreword separate from evidence furnished by the plays themselves.

Critical Perspective and Generic Differentiation

Five questions guide this study: (a) does a social problem become an event within the plot, or remain mere preaching? (b) what meanings arise from contradictions between the characters' words and conduct? (c) how do stage action, changes of scene, folk melodies, objects, and the presence of groups give meaning to the play? (d) does a woman's voice become her own decision,

or remain a moral lesson delivered by men? and (e) to what extent are these works appropriate for young readers and child performers?

Betik Apman is an extended social play in three acts: seven scenes in the first, six in the second, and nine in the third, making twenty-two scenes in all. *Chhinar Devi* is a one-act play in five scenes. The scene count is based on matching the headings to the scene divisions. The first play follows family life over successive periods, several occasions of marriage, and old age; the second compresses illness, suspicion, accusation, mediation, and dramatic resolution into a shorter time-span. In keeping with their different dimensions, the two plays differ in pace, organisation of dialogue, and stagecraft.

Betik Apman: A Separate Close Reading of Narrative Development Across Three Acts

Act One: From Preference for Sons to the Destruction of a Woman's Body

Scene 1: Desire, Regret, and Economic Calculation

After having three sons, Deepak expresses a desire for a daughter. Veena reminds him of his earlier suggestion that, had the foetus been female, an abortion should have been considered. At the outset, 'desire' becomes a form of moral regret: the absence of the daughter denied a chance of birth is now felt. Calculations of financial benefit and social expenditure are interwoven with love for sons. This marital conversation is more effective than an introductory lecture because the characters themselves bear witness to their past decisions.

> 'I wish I had a daughter. God has already given us three sons.'

Scene 2: Labour, Health, and Veena's Death

Domestic fuel, refreshments for workers in the fields, women's labour, and bodily illness lead from ordinary domestic feeling towards tragedy. Veena raises the physical cost of repeated pregnancies, terminations, and medication; her death then occurs onstage. The play shows its audience that the family's supposed 'protection of sons' sacrifices a woman's life. As drama, death is a means of producing an intense effect, but the representation of medical causation is a literary event and cannot be treated as independent medical evidence.

Scene 3: Self-Interest in Women's Labour Amid Bereavement

The widowed Deepak remembers his wife but soon connects the absence of someone to cook at home with the need for a daughter or daughter-in-law. Pradeep Kumar's advice is sympathetic, yet the risk of imagining a daughter as a provider of domestic services remains. Even after the loss of his wife, the division of labour does not change. The implication is that the crisis of the household is not simply the absence of a woman but also men's distance from domestic work.

Scene 4: Education Versus Domestic Utility

Deepak urges his sons to study, but, confronted with educational expenses and the problem of cooking, he pushes Mohan towards employment and an early marriage. Mohan's wish to continue studying, Sohan and Gopal's aspirations for school, and references to coaching centres reveal the dilemmas of rural education. Gopal's rhythmic speech makes the scene memorable for child performance; it also indicates the social acceptance of schools and facilities such as uniforms and midday meals. Education is an ideal, but the family's immediate economic needs obstruct it.

Scene 5: The Counterpoint of Balvir and Sunita

Balvir's confidence in his two daughters, Manju and Sanju, provides a counterpoint to Deepak's family. What matters is not the number of daughters but their upbringing and education. Sunita's initial desire for a son changes within the dialogue, a symbolic transformation. Nevertheless, the excessive emphasis on becoming 'doctors, engineers, police superintendents, or district collectors' risks turning daughters into instruments of social prestige rather than recognising their own existence. The scene is particularly strong in its concern with children's education and equal rights.

> 'Are daughters in any way inferior to sons?'

Scene 6: Shalini's Family and Class Difference

The poor farmer Harishchandra and Radha have a single daughter, Shalini. At first there is distress over the number of children, but the conversation turns to the ability to provide for them and the ethics of terminating a pregnancy. The challenge of educating a poor daughter emerges here as an independent issue. Balvir's daughters embody the dream of higher education; Shalini's education is a matter of arduous effort. Through these characters, the play suggests unequal opportunities shaped by class, although Shalini's own voice is still seldom heard.

Scene 7: The Return of the Marriage Question

Pradeep's advice to marry Mohan soon and Deepak's interest in possible dowry revive the moral contradiction of the first act. Compassionate regret over the absence of a daughter is translated once more into the search for a bride and the economics of exchange. Here the play's central irony is born: the man who regarded a daughter as an economic burden now treats a daughter-in-law as a solution to domestic problems and a source of dowry profit.

Act Two: The Marriage Market and the Humiliating Language of Dowry

Scene 1: A Surplus of Men Becomes the Plot's Economic Premise

Deepak approaches his friend Mahendra Pandit to find a bride for Mohan. Mahendra's words disclose an excess of young men and a shortage of young women. The consequences of earlier sex discrimination before birth now appear as a collective marriage crisis. The play tries to establish a cause-and-effect relationship between individual choices and their demographic

consequences, although the characters' experiences are not equivalent to a quantitative survey.

Scene 2: The Mediation of a Marriage Arrangement

Suresh Kamat becomes the marriage intermediary and raises a proposal involving Balvir's daughter. The scene suggests the social framework in which marriage involves a household, caste and kinship connections, the credibility of an intermediary, and an exchange of familial advantages. Female characters are not at the centre of direct decision-making here; negotiations among men dominate the stage.

Scene 3: Washing Feet and the Performance of Prestige

At the beginning of the marriage negotiations, Balvir's family insists on the ritual washing of feet. A humorous conflict arises between respect for custom and the authority claimed by the groom's side. The insistence upon washing feet, in fact, exposes relations of power expressed in the language of 'respect'. The use of a local custom gives the theatre a distinctive local identity, transforming the episode into action rather than a mere reference to ritual.

Scene 4: The Engagement Ritual, Exchange, and Decisions Made by Men

At Mohan's *chheka* ceremony, debates among numerous male characters, interruptions, betel and bidis, refreshments, the priest, ritual offerings, and folk songs combine to form the crowded theatrical arrangement of a rural marriage. The author's stage experience is clear here; nevertheless, the large cast, repeated remarks, and extended negotiations also slow the scene. Dowry ceases to be an aspect of emotional relationships and becomes bargaining, until marriage is scarcely distinguishable from commercial exchange.

Scene 5: Marriage Festivities and Satirical Performance

Preparations for the exchange of garlands, *parichhan* songs, interactions between wedding parties, and Gangaram's exaggerated behaviour create the festive surface of folk theatre. Humour concerning dowry, prestige, and hospitality produces dramatic pleasure, but the bride's missing individuality also creates a void: the wedding is spectacular onstage, while the independent wishes of the woman being married receive little attention.

Scene 6: Unfulfilled Dowry Expectations and Debt

Deepak's resentment at not receiving the expected dowry is the play's decisive irony. He has still not learned the human value of mothers and daughters: his wife is gone, but his greed survives. The burden of debt and signs of illness foreshadow the calamities of the third act. Compassion and ridicule focus on the same character; this mixed effect makes the play's ethical perspective more complex.

Act Three: The Reversal of Dowry and the Dramatic Culmination of Regret

Scene 1: Estrangement from Sons in Old Age

The ailing Deepak experiences neglect at the hands of his sons and daughters-in-law. Mahendra's suggestion that he remarry merely repeats the

old social structure instead of offering a solution: once again a woman is needed to provide care. The elderly man's pain is real, but the play also reveals that women's labour has been understood as the sole medium of familial affection.

Scene 2: Married Life in Delhi and Migration

Mohan and Manju's life in Delhi, a letter from the father, and the cost of returning to the village connect the economics of migration with distance from family responsibilities. Manju urges her husband to fulfil his obligations towards his father. In this scene, 'daughter' signifies not merely a numerical category within the family but also moral responsibility, although Manju's independent life remains only briefly developed in the text.

Scene 3: Public Acknowledgement of the Shortage of Girls

Pradeep explains to Deepak the links between dowry, the misuse of prenatal sex determination, and the declining availability of girls. The play makes its causal explanation explicit. Yet the extended speech momentarily leaves the dramatic scene and becomes social instruction. The urgency of the idea is important, but it requires equal discipline in its dramatic form.

> 'Dowry has disturbed the balance of the world and will continue to disturb it.'

Scene 4: The Reversal of Power in Shalini's Marriage Arrangement

The groom's party, arriving in Harishchandra's courtyard, now finds itself in the position of supplicants. The headman Raman Kumar sets the terms of the marriage. The traditional positions of dowry-giver and dowry-recipient are reversed: the match is now settled upon a demand of fifty-one thousand rupees from the groom's family. The reversal produces a dramatic miracle of reform, but not an egalitarian marriage. Changing the direction of payment does not end the objectification of either women or men. The author's criticism emerges through economic satire; readers should not mistake it for a complete model of women's rights.

Scene 5: The Promise of Money and the Halted Exchange of Garlands

The wedding of Shalini, where the exchange of garlands cannot proceed until money has been handed over, becomes a mirror image of the dowry system. The old arrogance of the groom's family now experiences humiliation itself. In categorical terms, this is retaliatory justice—not the abolition of exploitation, but its repetition in reverse. The halted garland ceremony could become an effective stage action, since the audience witnesses the public discomfort of the transaction instead of merely hearing about it.

Scene 6: An Elderly Man's Financial Exhaustion

Deepak's worsening illness, wedding expenses, and continuing dissatisfaction give bodily form to the deterioration caused by social greed. Illness repeatedly serves in the play as a measure of moral punishment. This structure resembles a folk moral tale; contemporary criticism may ask how far the tendency to regard illness as the consequence of wrongdoing accords with modern ethics of compassion and care.

Scene 7: The Search for Gopal's Marriage Match

Returning to Suresh reveals the recurring cycle of marriage arrangements. Deepak has not learned the proper lesson from his encounters with dowry: a new version of scarcity, helplessness, and calculation appears. Repetition sharpens the author's satire, although a more compressed organisation of scenes could have made it still more effective.

Scene 8: Bargaining by the Bride's Side Reaches Its Height

The occasion of Gopal's marriage again introduces a cash transaction and a condition attached to the exchange of garlands. The old language of social prestige returns to the stage in satirical reversal. Marriage customs, the son-in-law's position, and male prestige all become targets of humour. Nevertheless, the work retains an important limitation: a solution supportive of daughters' rights would require education, inheritance, mutual consent, and freedom—not merely a new custom of taking money from the groom's family.

Final Scene: Regret, Sons and Daughters-in-Law, and Death

Family disputes, the arrival of a doctor, and final repentance at the suffering Deepak's deathbed constitute the culmination of the play's moral outcome. Veena's death in the first act and Deepak's at the end together form a circle of familial tragedy. This circle gives the play a didactic conclusion, but collective accusations against the children, illness represented as punishment, and an excessively prolonged death scene sometimes submerge the experience of compassion beneath pronouncement.

Chhinar Devi: A Close Reading of Five Scenes and Their Ideological Conflict

Scene 1: Lalan's Unusual Behaviour and the Arrival of a Ritual Healer

Lalan, the son of Subhash and Meera, behaves in an unstable and aggressive manner. Rather than investigating the cause, the family begins to attribute his conduct to the influence of a spirit or goddess. Sukhal Kiyot, a ritual healer, is summoned; he performs rituals and asks questions but finally admits his inability to help. This admission is an important disruptive moment: the healer is no longer an all-knowing character who possesses a complete solution. Yet the scene offers no clear medical diagnosis of the condition.

Scene 2: Witchcraft Accusations, Family Disintegration, and Resistance

The interpretation of Lalan's conduct turns into an accusation against Sukni, a woman in the family. Rumours gain social force through neighbourhood characters, including Matuk and Raju. Sukni's son Soman resists in order to protect his mother. The possibility of violence, public humiliation, and threats to life in the name of identifying a witch makes this the play's most acute scene. It shows that superstition is not merely a personal delusion but can become a means of destroying relationships and perpetrating mob violence.

Scene 3: Parbatiya's Assumed Divine Persona and Reason

In the character description, Parbatiya Koir is called a psychologist, yet onstage she enters in a trance resembling that of a ritual healer, repeatedly cries 'Bolo Jai Ganga', and assumes the guise associated with Kali and spirit-possession. This double appearance can be understood as an authorial strategy: entering the language of faith in order to break a delusion generated by faith. She reasons against the supposed omnipotence of witches and identifies the accusation as a suspicion of the mind. This is the play's intellectual high point.

> 'Belief in witches is sheer superstition.'

Yet Parbatiya also proposes early marriage as a remedy for Lalan's condition. Here opposition to superstition conflicts with an unsubstantiated expectation that marriage can function as treatment. The very character who seeks to change society's outlook redirects the problem of illness away from medical investigation towards marriage as a solution. Acknowledging the author's reformist intention does not justify concealing this inconsistency.

Scene 4: Anu Anjana, a Temple Wedding, and the Question of Consent

Ghatakraj immediately proposes marriage as the remedy; with the assistance of Vinod Jha, Lalan and Anu Anjana are married at the Kali temple in Amolagachhi. Humour, a small ritual fee, the chanting of mantras, and the impatience of the bride and groom animate the scene. References to Anu Anjana's earlier marriages generate unusual character-based comedy. The critical question, however, is how the marriage of a young man with unstable behaviour, after he has been calmed with medication, should be evaluated in terms of consent, health, and informed understanding. The text does not adequately resolve this question.

Scene 5: Alleged Recovery and Moral Pronouncement

The concluding scene shows Lalan at peace and ends with Parbatiya's words of wisdom. The restoration of harmony in Subhash's household is the author's desired outcome. But the suggestion of a 'complete recovery' immediately after marriage simplifies the complex possible medical causes of unusual behaviour. The expectation of a happy ending in popular performance is satisfied; the realistic analysis of the problem remains incomplete.

> 'Lost in superstition, people drive their lives into an abyss.'

Women's Voices, Patriarchy, and the Limits of Social Reform

Veena is the first powerful voice in *Betik Apman*. She questions her husband's prioritisation of wealth, dowry, and sons. Her resistance arises from real experiences of bodily labour, the suffering of terminated pregnancies, and self-respect. The tragedy is that, in order to teach society a moral lesson, the plot treats her death as a necessary event. Veena's suffering is powerfully conveyed, but her living resistance is not allowed to remain at the centre of the story for long.

Manju and Sanju mark the possibilities open to educated daughters; Shalini is a daughter deprived of opportunities by poverty; Radha and Sunita express different kinds of social experience. Nevertheless, men generally determine the economic terms of marriage throughout the three acts. The title protests against the humiliation of daughters, but questions concerning girls' wishes, property rights, higher education, and marital autonomy are comparatively underdeveloped. This limitation can be understood in the social context of the period, but criticism should not disguise it as a virtue.

In *Chhinar Devi*, Sukni is the direct victim of the witchcraft accusation. Parbatiya is an unusual but effective representative of female reasoning, constructing a familiar language of scientific scepticism while disguised as a ritual healer. The play's originality lies in this contradiction. A woman being accused and another woman refuting the accusation at the same time produces social symbolism. Nevertheless, a fuller presentation of Sukni's independent perspective would have exposed the direct human cost of the culture of accusation more clearly.

Dramatic Craft: Vernacular Expressions, Repetition, Humour, Stage Properties, and Performability

The language of Bechan Thakur's dialogue is predominantly rural Maithili. Characters construct their social milieu through expressions such as *mal-pani*, *bhansa-bhat*, *nañ/nai*, *gora lagnai*, *duar*, *chheka*, and *samdhi*. Here the emotional reality of the plays depends more on the rhythms of vernacular speech than on strictly formal language. Insulting forms of address, repetition, exaggeration, reversals of social prestige, and ritual conversations produce the humour. Dialogue sometimes becomes excessively expansive, but that very expansiveness preserves the collective living speech of the stage.

The stage properties are especially worthy of examination: chairs, water vessels, bowls for washing feet, the ceremonial tray for *chheka*, bedding, letters, chewing tobacco, the *mridanga* drum, earth, sacred ash, vessels for a sick person, a wedding pavilion, and cash fees for rituals. These objects are more than signs of village life. They enable actors' movements, waiting, comings and goings, laughter, tension, and processes of public decision-making. Repeated settings such as the house, verandah, courtyard, and temple make these works potentially easy to stage in local theatres with limited resources.

The twenty-two scenes of *Betik Apman* embrace so many situations that they sometimes resemble a social survey; the narrative centre consequently shifts at times from Deepak's transformation to the technical bargaining involved in marriage. The close sequence of five scenes in *Chhinar Devi* is relatively concentrated, but carelessness in presenting the causes of Lalan's unusual conduct and constructing humour around Anu Anjana's character may trouble contemporary audiences. Scenes involving threats of violence need to be directed with critical distance.

Comparison of the dramatic endings is also revealing. The first play closes with death and remorse; the second with marriage and peace. One makes a social warning through the punishment of a character, while the other declares the problem resolved through cultural reconciliation. These endings exemplify two distinct techniques of reformist theatre: instruction through fear and instruction through a happy ending.

The History of Children's Literature and Student Theatre: A Comparative Discussion

Generic clarity is essential from the outset: judged by their own texts, *Betik Apman* and *Chhinar Devi* are family-centred social plays primarily concerning adults. A work does not automatically become children's literature because children or students perform it. The identity of children's literature depends on children's experiential perspectives, narrative accessibility, emotional suitability for their age, imagination, opportunities to question, pleasure, and the context of presentation. On this basis, it is appropriate to give Bechan Thakur's work particular importance in the history of 'community theatre involving children', but it would be wrong to include it in a strictly generic catalogue of children's plays without qualification.

Videha's book repository makes *Dhurta-Samagama* and other older plays available as records of earlier Maithili theatrical traditions. Thakur's affinity with these traditions is to be sought not in Sanskrit-oriented dramatic forms but in the humorous exposure of social pretence, ritual, and absurdity. Earlier farce makes the ostentation of religious authority an object of irony; in *Chhinar Devi*, the language of the ritual healer is turned into a vehicle for reason opposed to superstition. This is a comparative suggestion, not a historical claim of direct influence.

The contemporary *Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra*, published in Videha, proposes various criteria for young readers, including aesthetic experience, appropriateness, narrative structure, and linguistic simplicity. On these criteria, Thakur's plays possess the strengths of immediately intelligible vernacular language, song and dialogue, theatrical action, and social questioning. Yet episodes involving termination of pregnancy, death, violent threats of witchcraft accusations, and marriage transactions cannot be considered suitable for younger children without educational adaptation. For older student performers, however, the texts can certainly provide a basis for discussing consent, health, gender justice, and superstition.

A comparative review of Dr Amarendra's *Angika Bal-Sahitya*, published in Videha, views the history of writing for children as an extended cultural genealogy, from lullabies, play songs, riddles, and stories to one-act plays of the modern era. From this perspective, Thakur's student performances bridge written drama and the oral culture of the community. Even so, the generic histories of Angika and Maithili literature are not identical; the comparison here is restricted to the cultural medium of performance by children.

Videha's series *Maithili Natyamanch/Natak Lel Ekta Samiksha Siddhant* and contemporary critical materials such as *Natya-Navagraha* provide a basis for locating dramatic meaning not only in printed dialogue but also in performance, audience relationships, and structures of social power. Information about performances by female students and festive village staging in Thakur's practice is important in this respect: it reveals a shared domain of school education and popular participation within the history of dramatic literature. The available information does not, however, permit the reconstruction of a year-by-year history of the plays performed, numbers of actors, or actual audience responses. [5–6]

Possibilities and Limitations from the Perspective of Children's Theatre

In the study of children's theatre, the relationship between a work and its performance operates in both directions. If students perform a serious story, acting can develop confidence in public speaking, pronunciation, memory, solidarity, and the capacity for social dialogue. But when the social philosophy of the text concerns traumatic experiences beyond the actors' ages, teachers and directors need to understand the sensitivity of those situations. Veena's physical suffering, threats of violence against Sukni, and the question of consent to marriage particularly demand child-sensitive discussion. Unless such distinctions are considered properly, the category of 'children's drama' may expand until it becomes meaningless.

Moral Outcomes and Critical Achievements: Four Comparative Conclusions

First, the roots of social crisis in both plays lie in collective attitudes. Behind individual decisions about pregnancy shaped by discrimination against girls is the economic ideology of dowry; behind individual fears that produce witchcraft accusations lie neighbourhood pressure, kinship, and invented forms of authority. This shared structure makes the inclusion of both plays in one book meaningful.

Second, both plays seek to teach through consequences: a woman's death and an old man's regret in *Betik Apman*, Parbatiya's reasoning and a happy ending in *Chhinar Devi*. But overly simple depictions of causation sometimes diminish the complexities of actual social life. Contemporary restaging of subjects such as abortion, mental health, and domestic violence should be non-discriminatory, centred on victims, and sensitive to evidence.

Third, the playwright's most successful technique is the creation of a 'speaking society'. The stage does not belong to one protagonist's monologue: it is filled with the voices of uncles, maternal uncles, neighbours, headmen, children, healers, priests, brides and grooms, doctors, and women of the household. Social incongruity is exposed through this many-voiced world. Repetition, extended bargaining, and excessive moral instruction, however, sometimes blunt the subject's edge.

Fourth, although women's emancipation is a major ethical strength of the plays, the question remains incompletely realised within them. The demand that daughters not be killed is an essential beginning for women's right to life, but literary examination must then consider women's own rights over marriage, education, inheritance, their bodies, health, and decisions. The teaching of reason in *Chhinar Devi* will likewise be complete only when respectful mental-health care and marital consent become central to the narrative alongside the repudiation of witchcraft accusations.

Ideological Echoes in Dialogue

These passages concentrate the tensions surrounding family decisions, the position of women, and the contradictions of reformist thought.

> 'I wish I had a daughter. God has already given us three sons.'

Character: Deepak; *Betik Apman*, Act One, Scene One.

> 'Are daughters in any way inferior to sons?'

Character: Balvir; *Betik Apman*, Act One, Scene Five.

> 'Dowry has disturbed the balance of the world and will continue to disturb it.'

Character: Pradeep; *Betik Apman*, Act Three, Scene Three.

> 'Belief in witches is sheer superstition.'

Character: Parbatiya; *Chhinar Devi*, Scene Three.

> 'Lost in superstition, people drive their lives into an abyss.'

Character: Subhash; *Chhinar Devi*, Final Scene.

Conclusion

Betik Apman a Chhinar Devi should be regarded as an important work of social reformist theatre rooted in Mithila's village society. Its literary strength lies in its closeness to lived experience, colloquial Maithili, the theatrical potential of folk customs, accessible humour, effective exposure of women's suffering, and public opposition to violence born of superstition. The plays do not merely oppose two different social evils; both show them as consequences of a shared collective ignorance and unequal distribution of power.

Alongside these strengths, the limitations are clear: amid declarations about education, women's autonomous voices remain restricted; the reversal of financial transactions takes precedence over the abolition of dowry; and the tendency to regard marriage as a cure for illness contradicts scientific understanding. For this reason, the plays' concluding moral pronouncements cannot be exempted from critical questioning. This does not lessen Bechan Thakur's importance; it makes it more historically specific, for his theatrical world records both our society's desire for change and its contradictions.

In literary histories of writing for children, the collection is more appropriately situated in the context of Maithili community theatre involving

students than categorised solely as children's drama proper. The stage contributions of female students recorded in the author's statement and earlier publications in Videha establish this connection. While preserving the limits of what the available records can support, the most useful future task for theatrical history would be to collect original scripts, performance versions, interviews with actors, production dates, and audience recollections.

03 / 06

Bap Bhel Pitti and Adhikar

From Oppressive Fatherhood to Citizens' Rights

Introducing the Two Works

Bechan Thakur's *Bap Bhel Pitti a Adhikar* is a paired volume of plays published by Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, in 2012. The first play develops children's conflict within the family across three acts; the second raises issues of citizens' rights, housing assistance, and resistance to corruption.

The Dramatic Vision: A Shared Principle in Both Plays

The protagonists of both works stand outside the centres of power and resources. In the first, Manoj and Santosh are children deprived of rights within their own home; in the second, Manjur is a poor citizen rendered helpless before village administration. In the first, the language of humiliation begins at home and closes the doors of school; in the second, it begins with the distance between a chair and the floor and spreads towards the door of the state. This similarity makes the publication of these plays together a meaningful critical unit.

Their structural difference is nevertheless fundamental. The first play follows an emotional and ethical journey across three acts, through domestic opposition, song, an accident, success, and reunion. The second constructs a civic campaign in fifteen scenes, moving from applications to offices and from offices to public recognition. This contrast clarifies two approaches to social reality: changing minds through compassion and changing institutions through rights.

Bap Bhel Pitti: Narrative, Characters, and Three-Act Structure

Making the father's failure central to the title is critically significant. Lakhan's first wife has died; his sons Manoj and Santosh are still children. After he decides to remarry, the new wife Meena privileges her own children, while the sons of the first marriage struggle for fair shares of food and education. The title's concern is not simply 'a stepmother's cruelty' but also the father's moral passivity.

As a counter-narrative, Ramlal's household emerges, initially showing two wives, children, and mutual cooperation living together. This parallel home is not intended as the author's comprehensive survey of reality but as a dramatic model for comparison: in one household resources are divided unequally; in the other, collective care is idealised. The contrast is attractive, but it should not be mistaken for a sociologically universal picture of the ideal family.

Act One: From the Decision to Marry to the Beginnings of Discrimination

Scene 1: Concerned about raising his two sons, Lakhan considers a second marriage. Bauhu's warning introduces the dangers of step-relationships. The seeds of future disaster are sown here, because the children's clear consent or wishes never become questions in the adults' decision.

Scene 2: Madan's home becomes the setting for negotiations over the marriage alliance. Kinship, the intermediary's assurances, and pressure for an early wedding give the drama the momentum of customary marriage arrangements. The woman's concerns remain secondary; here marriage is a device of the plot rather than an account of the woman's own life.

Scene 3: At the wedding in the Shiva temple, the questions of Manoj and Santosh, expectations of music and dancing, and the priest's preoccupation with his fee generate humour. The children's humour puts adult customs on trial, while the question of ritual payment satirises the economics of religious ceremony.

Scene 4: The introduction to Ramlal, Lakshmi, and Santoshi's household portrays a united family devoted to education. Their straightforward arrangement for paying school fees establishes a sharp contrast with the educational deprivation that will emerge in Lakhan's family.

Scene 5: The headman Ramakant and ward member Baldev arrive to discuss housing assistance. The financial exchange provides an early image of the state's presence in rural life; the episode may be read as an indirect foreshadowing of the housing-scheme problem in the companion play *Adhikar*. This is an intertextual interpretation, not a declared authorial plan.

Scene 6: During play with her own son and daughter, Meena treats her stepsons differently. Krishna's question—why children of the same father should be treated unequally—is an important moment of children's sense of justice. Here a child makes an ethical judgement independently.

Act Two: The Denial of Children's Rights and Extraordinary Resistance

Scene 1: In Ramlal's household, a quarrel begins over food involving the unwell Soni and Santoshi. Lakshmi intervenes, and Ramlal establishes harmony. The playwright turns a crisis in the joint household into a rapid resolution; this idealisation assists comparison but reduces psychological complexity.

Scene 2: Manoj and Santosh ask to be enrolled in school. Lakhan withdraws, pleading financial inability, while Meena arranges schooling for her own

children. The two boys are eventually beaten and driven away. This is the play's ethical centre: two standards of education within one household.

Scene 3: After leaving home, Manoj and Santosh receive food and sympathy from Radha. She becomes their first social refuge in rebuilding their lives and encourages them not to abandon their studies. The play creates an alternative set of human relationships beyond the home.

Scene 4: The brothers plan to beg by singing folk songs to the rhythm of plates and metal vessels. Their private humiliation becomes public song; their decision to spend the money they receive on education rather than private comforts constitutes a declaration of self-discipline with political implications.

> 'First, my boy, make arrangements for your studies.' — Manoj

Scene 5: With Manoj and Santosh absent, the unequal power within Meena and Lakhan's relationship becomes clear. Meena takes pride in her children's school achievements, but the results do not meet her expectations. The plot shows that money and favouritism cannot guarantee academic success.

Scene 6: The railway-station scene marks a leap in time. A bus accident during a school excursion costs Manoj an arm and Santosh his sight. Santosh's song joins together the loss of home, the struggle for education, and disability. The resulting suffering gives the narrative a dense tragic feeling, although the presentation of realistic causation is sharply compressed.

> 'Blind now, I could not study.' — From Santosh's song

Act Three: Failed Arrogance, Achievement, and Reconciliation

Scene 1: Lakhan performs household labour, while Meena has high expectations for the examination results of her two children. When Rampari and Krishna fail, Meena decides to stop their education. Schooling here becomes not a right but a privilege dependent on competitive success.

Scene 2: The family's happy response to children's examination results in Ramlal's household presents education as a shared delight. The scene sharply reverses the punitive response to results in Lakhan's household.

Scene 3: Santosh continues to sing folk songs at the railway station, while Manoj returns with news of his success in the administrative services. His acknowledgement of his younger brother and the people who helped him is a moment of moral reciprocity in the story's structure.

> 'I shall remain grateful to him all my life.' — Manoj

Scene 4: The appearance of the impoverished Ramlal at the collector's residence, and his meeting with Santosh, bring administrative prestige together with the social needs of the poor. Differences in identity, identification documents, and relationships of service create a new equation of human relations onstage.

Scene 5: Manoj and Santosh consider marriage proposals. In judging between a woman in a high-ranking position and one with comparatively

fewer formal qualifications, the characters reason about prestige, household relationships, and family closeness. Their evaluations are not free of gendered expectations.

Scene 6: Manoj and Soni's marriage at the Kali temple joins strands of the family plot. Comparison with the wedding in the first act suggests that ideals of social trust and mutual respect have advanced, although the resolution of the marriage episode is exceptionally rapid.

Scene 7: Meena's illness and Lakhan's helplessness reverse the balance of domestic power. Those children's voices that were suppressed are remembered in their absence as the family again falls into distress. The portrayal of illness risks turning it into a moral instrument of punishment.

Scene 8: Humorous exchanges at the collector's residence and the presence of Virbhadra introduce a lighter rhythm into administrative life. Talk of returning to the village moves the narrative towards an anticipated reunion, though some of the humour distracts attention from the work's central questions of children's rights.

Scene 9: Manoj and Santosh arrive at Lakhan's home when Meena is gravely ill. Although the memory of past humiliation remains, they insist that she receive treatment. The scene constructs an ethical choice between revenge and care.

Scene 10: Medical assistance, blood matching, surgery, and recognition of relationships in the hospital bring the plot to a close. Manoj assists with treatment, and Meena's remorse emerges. The emotional happy ending of forgiveness conveys a social message, but the question of structural redress for the violence suffered by the children remains unanswered.

Central Critical Questions of the First Play

The passivity of fatherhood. On the surface, Meena resembles an unmistakable antagonist, but Lakhan's actions require re-examination. He does not intervene decisively to secure his sons' admission to school; after they are driven out, he does not properly investigate their whereabouts; and he submits to the other authority within the family. The play's real indictment is therefore not directed at a woman alone but at fatherhood that evades moral responsibility. The title supports this reading.

Children's agency. Manoj and Santosh are not passive objects of pity. Excluded from their own home, they create songs, seek help from the public, deliberate over the use of their money, and make education their first priority. The work is consequently an important document of children's experience. Yet the question arises whether a narrative that leaves children to beg for the opportunity to study might, if treated merely as an inspirational success story, conceal the failure of social protection systems.

A critique of disability. After the bus accident, Manoj's loss of an arm and Santosh's blindness abruptly intensify the play's suffering. Santosh's song draws public sympathy, and his efforts to ensure that his brother continues studying

constitute a positive form of agency. Yet his swift abandonment of opportunities for his own education needs criticism. Stage adaptation could introduce questions of independent educational possibilities and accessibility. Disability must not be made merely an object of pity: this is an essential criterion for a modern rereading of the text.

Imbalance in the female characters. Meena is largely rendered as one-dimensional cruelty, Lakshmi and Santoshi as harmony, Radha as service, and Soni as affection. This division sharpens theatrical contrast but gives little scope to the social pressures, psychological alternatives, and economic autonomy of women. The difficulties of step-relationships should therefore be understood within the structure of family power rather than attributed wholesale to the nature of women.

The question of medium. Across the third act, the narrative makes a great leap from the opening school scenes to success in the administrative services. Signals of passing time are comparatively few; songs, repetition, and symbolic entrances connect events. Here the dramatic craft chooses the swift sense of justice characteristic of folk theatre over the careful progression of realism.

Adhikar: A Civic Drama in Fifteen Scenes

The protagonist of *Adhikar*, Manjur, is a rickshaw puller afflicted by a flood-damaged shelter, meagre earnings, and corrupt practices of rural authority. Headman Chandan and his associate Amarnath demand a bribe for housing assistance. An ally named Vinod helps Manjur with applications. Manjur accepts the need to approach block, subdivision, district, political, and information-commission authorities. The narrative concludes with newspaper coverage, a public ceremony of honour, and the headman's repentance.

The title *Adhikar* ('Right') signifies more than a demand for personal benefit. Manjur's experience asks who will close the gap between a written welfare scheme and practical access to it. In this play, a right is not merely a legal term; it is the citizen's courage to speak, capacity to demand evidence, and ability to refuse humiliation. Yet the unusually brief response periods mentioned in the play's applications and its descriptions of institutional procedures should be understood as dramatic representations, not as legally verified rules.

A Scene-by-Scene Examination

Scene 1: In headman Chandan's verandah, Manjur sits on the ground and regards the chair as a symbol of high office. The demand for a five-thousand-rupee bribe out of a twenty-thousand-rupee housing grant exposes the injustice of power. The distance between chair and floor is the play's first effective visual metaphor.

Scene 2: In conversation with Vinod, Manjur first discovers a practical legal course of action. Although he is not literate, he understands the moral legitimacy of his claim. By preparing written applications, Vinod bridges the gap between literacy and rights.

Scene 3: In his first written petition to the headman, Manjur requests both housing assistance and information. Chandan's ridicule stages institutional despotism. Manjur's resistance now changes from supplication into a written challenge.

Scene 4: Vinod prepares applications for the BDO, SDO, and DM. The administrative hierarchy becomes a kind of staircase within the play: each new door increases both hope and fear.

Scene 5: At the block development office, the petition is disregarded. The action of throwing an application into the rubbish is an exact visual image of contempt for rights on paper. The conflict becomes one between official language and living hunger.

Scene 6: Repeated journeys to the subdivision office make visible the continuing cost in labour of seeking justice. For an already poor citizen, leaving daily work to visit offices is itself a punishment. The scene thus suggests the economic dimension of an administrative journey.

Scene 7: Before Collector Chandrakant at the district headquarters, Manjur's petition also fails to produce the desired result. The conduct of lower-level employees and neglect from above together reveal institutional insensitivity. The object of criticism is no longer one office's mistake but a succession of failures across the system.

Scene 8: Exhausted after fifteen days, Vinod initially advises him to concede defeat, but Manjur wishes to continue. The protagonist's patience here confronts his companion's sense of practical reality.

Scene 9: A meeting with Shyamanand opens the way to a petition before the information commissioner. The role of a popular intermediary in securing justice is shown; yet dependence on the sudden intervention of a 'good leader' partially transfers the critique of institutions onto individual goodwill.

Scene 10: Scarcity in Manjur's household, his wife Najima's worries, insufficient travel money, and a handful of puffed rice constitute the real economic ground of his civic movement. This is one of the most poignant scenes because the administrative procedure is connected to hunger at home.

Scene 11: In the information commissioner's office, Manjur's efforts receive praise. Journalists make his story public. A private grievance thus becomes a public example of citizenship, although the narrative does not detail a decisive official order.

Scene 12: The attention of media representative Akhilesh turns towards Manjur. The press constructs his story as that of an extraordinary citizen. Publicity is a motivating force in the play, but the distance between success in the headlines and real institutional reform needs examination.

Scene 13: The preparations for Manjur's family to travel to Delhi include children's lively questions and domestic humour. Conversations involving Najima, Salma, and others reveal the collective delight of a civic achievement,

although women's independent consciousness of rights receives limited attention.

Scene 14: Manjur receives an award at a ceremony in Delhi. His speech raises the question of the public's participation in the birth and nurture of corruption. This is the play's intellectual climax, although the speech of praise becomes prolonged and diminishes dramatic confrontation.

Scene 15: The headman arrives offering the twenty-thousand-rupee assistance and an additional five thousand from his own funds. Manjur first rejects money acquired illegitimately, then makes public good conduct the condition of forgiveness. Vinod's concluding statement connects education with the prevention of corruption.

> 'I do not want ill-gotten money.' — Manjur
>
> 'Victory to Hind! Victory to India!! Victory to Education!!!' — Final exclamation

The Craft and Heroism of *Adhikar*

The making of a democratic protagonist. Manjur's distinctive quality lies not in higher education, economic power, or inherited prestige but in his determination not to abandon a just demand. From the first scene to the last, his linguistic diffidence diminishes. Initially, he does not consider himself entitled to sit in a chair; at the end, he takes a promise from society that everyone will be treated well. This gradual acquisition of self-respect is the play's most convincing internal progression.

Records, applications, and stage objects. Papers, files, petitions, chairs, security gates, and ceremonial garlands are not merely decorations in this play; they are tangible signs of power. Chandan's chair and Manjur's place on the floor, the officer's file and the application thrown into the rubbish, and finally the garland placed on a citizen—all these stages transform meaning through objects. The method is useful for theatre with limited resources.

The ethics of mediation. Without Vinod, Manjur's struggle would not have advanced so far. This cooperation raises a question about the civic rights of people who cannot read or write: beyond being constitutionally established, rights require the practical ability to prepare written applications. Yet Vinod's assistance does not erase the protagonist's independence; Manjur himself makes the final decisions and endures the journeys and hardships.

Religious and social plurality. Domestic scenes involving Manjur, Najima, and their children, alongside the presence of Vinod, Shyamanand, and the officials, place the drama on the common ground of citizenship. Characters' names certainly suggest cultural diversity, but the work's central conflict is not communal; it is economic, class-related, and administrative. This analysis does not make unverified assumptions about caste or community beyond what the text establishes.

The limits of the happy ending. After the initial failures of the officials, journalism, an award, and the headman's rapid repentance make all the

problems appear resolved. This is the structure of moral victory in folk drama. Yet important questions remain about its cost: what became of the administrative status of the application? What process followed the bribery complaint? Did the experiences of other people change? The play is relatively silent about these institutional answers.

Dialogue, Compassion, and Resistance

Selected dialogue from the two plays reveals distinct forms of familial compassion and civic resistance. At decisive moments, the characters' words intensify the dramatic meaning.

The words 'First, my boy, make arrangements for your studies' show the child protagonist's priorities in spending money. 'Blind now, I could not study' turns a personal account into the pain of separation from the wish to learn. Read together, they make clear both the importance of education and how unrealised the desire may remain when the means of access are destroyed. Manoj's acknowledgement of Santosh as the source of his success forms an ethical axis of reciprocity.

In *Adhikar*, 'I do not want ill-gotten money' expresses the protagonist's distinction between the purpose of state assistance and improper personal advantage. 'Victory to Hind! Victory to India!! Victory to Education!!!' finally translates the discourse of civic rights into a collective ideal centred on education. Dramaturgically, however, the closing slogan also risks narrowing the multiplicity of meanings in dialogue to a one-dimensional lesson.

Comparative Contexts in the History of Children's Literature

A decision about whether a work belongs to children's drama must consider not only its subject but also its intended readers, linguistic complexity, performance length, representation of violent scenes, child characters' activity, and young audiences' capacity to absorb emotional distress. Children occupy the centre of *Bap Bhel Pitti*, and some episodes may be adapted for children's theatre. Yet the complete three-act play deals at length with adult marriage, domestic violence, begging, a serious accident, medical treatment, and the happy ending of marriage. To declare it unambiguously a play exclusively for children would therefore be generically inaccurate. In *Adhikar*, children are supporting characters; the principal focus is campaigning for rights and administrative conduct.

Videha's available reference materials provide a historical background to this distinction. Phulchandra Jha 'Praveen's' *Maithili Shishu Lok Sahitya* (Videha, issue 50, 2010) and Yoganand Jha's *Maithili Bal-Lokkatha: Sthiti a Apeksha* (issue 76, 2011) make children's oral traditions objects of study. Durganand Mandal's *Nena Lel Sundar Chitrakatha* (issue 116, 2012) is evidence of discussion concerning children's visual worlds. Explicit entries for these essays are available in Videha's archives, but detailed arguments from unavailable original essays have not been attributed to their authors here.

Videha's 2012 report on *Sagar Rati Dip Jaray* contains notice of the launch of this book by Bechan Thakur. The same report also mentions *Bal Mandali/Kishor Jagat*, *Videha Shishu Utsav*, and other dramatic works. It thus offers evidence of a contemporary publishing environment containing both children's and adolescents' literature and adult social drama. It cannot, however, determine from a single report the 'first' or 'largest' achievements across the whole history of Maithili children's literature.

A critical entry titled *Maithili Balnatak Sima Vistar Karait—Chauari*, by Ramesh Ranjan (Videha, issue 126, 15 March 2013), identifies children's theatre as a distinct object of study. In 2026, Gajendra Thakur's *Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra* (Videha, issue 447) expands questions of children's agency, social perspectives, and appropriateness. *Natya-Navagraha*, in the same issue, provides a useful comparative basis for thinking about the differences between children's and adult drama. These studies were published after the 2012 plays; their concepts are therefore applied here as later critical criteria, not as the playwright's declared intentions at the time.

Childhood Experience and Civic Experience: Comparative Criteria

The first criterion is the child's right to speak. In *Bap Bhel Pitti*, Krishna asks his mother why children of the same father face discrimination; Manoj and Santosh demand school admission and make decisions of their own beyond merely receiving readers' sympathy. In *Adhikar*, Manjur is an adult, but his applications likewise tell the story of a humiliated human being recovering his voice. Both plays can serve civic education, though the different forms of children's and adults' experiences must remain distinct.

The second criterion is song and participation onstage. The public-singing scene in the first play may be particularly suitable for children's and adolescents' theatre because it unites speech, rhythm, a collective audience, and a demand for justice. In the second, reading applications, passing through office doors, and public recognition are the principal stage actions. Short educational adaptations are possible on this basis, but the intended audience of the complete plays does not automatically change.

The third criterion is the presentation of suffering. For young audiences, expulsion from home, violence, accidents, and disability must be staged with sensitivity and age-appropriate visual planning. The task is not to diminish the suffering of the work's original reality but to exercise care over the degree and viewpoint of its representation. Making drama a one-way vehicle for moral lessons can reduce children's own right to ask questions.

Rasa, Language, Stagecraft, and Folk Society

Compassion and resistance. In *Bap Bhel Pitti*, the sources of *karuna rasa*, the aesthetic emotion of pathos, are children's hunger, rejection, and the accident. Their song turns private sorrow into collective compassion. Success in the third act introduces heroic enthusiasm and the tranquillity of reconciliation. In *Adhikar*, resistance grows out of initial destitution;

Manjur's successive campaigns through files and applications create a popular civic form of heroic *rasa*.

Humour and satire. Wedding rituals, the priest's fees, children's lively speech, Virbhadra's mixed language, and humour surrounding the journey to Delhi punctuate the plays' serious themes. Yet some jokes become excessively long and reduce characters to vehicles for comic business. Greater discipline of form could sharpen both dramatic momentum and social criticism.

Linguistic diversity. Rural Maithili underlies the dialogue, while administrative vocabulary, Hindi-influenced expressions, English titles, and Sanskrit-derived mantras move through it. This mixture should not be judged according to a simplistic binary of 'pure' and 'impure', but read in relation to characters' class, profession, situation, and irony. Original spellings are preserved in quotations in the Maithili study, while its critical prose is presented in standard Maithili.

The practicalities of staging. Verandahs, roads, schools, stations, hospitals, offices, and ceremonies create numerous locations. In low-budget productions, a fixed bench and chair, lighting changes, and sound cues could signal changes of place. The hospital and accident in the first play and the public Delhi ceremony in the second, however, require additional theatrical adaptation. A dramatic text must not be assumed to be the same as a successful performance.

Conflicts, Contradictions, and Critical Limitations

1. Idealisation of the family: Ramlal's family is a valuable point of comparison, but its very easy reconciliation diminishes the real depth of serious domestic conflicts. Conversely, Meena's virtually uninterrupted negativity makes the antagonist flat.

2. Justice through achievement: Manoj's success in the administrative services is constructed as historical compensation for the children's suffering. Yet countless deprived children do not attain high office; their rights are no less important. The ethics of educational justice are broader than rewards based on achievement.

3. Life with disability: Santosh's continuation of education after becoming blind is uncertain. The establishment of self-respect through service to his brother is moving, but independent resources, education, and public accessibility require fuller treatment.

4. Gender assumptions: Meena's exclusively negative portrayal, the centrality of marriage and service in the construction of female characters, and the predominance of the ideal-wife image deserve critical attention. Including women's alternative perspectives would increase the story's social capacity.

5. Procedural representation of rights: *Adhikar* simplifies the provisions governing the right to information for dramatic purposes. It should therefore

be understood as a cultural text fostering awareness of rights, not as a verified model of a legal application. If research turns to legal history, separate official records must be examined.

6. Resolution through personal honour: Manjur's award and the headman's apology provide the reassurance of a happy ending, but are insufficient measures of systemic reform. The play could have given greater scope to collective monitoring and public accountability as lasting forms of resistance to corruption.

7. Extended explanatory dialogue: In the second play, the length of application forms and final speeches sometimes produces declarative addresses rather than active drama. Selective editing for performance could improve the pace while retaining the original arguments.

Videha's Contemporary Context and the Place of the Text

In the original volume, editor Gajendra Thakur comments extensively on Bechan Thakur's theatrical practice, rural theatre, and the critical environment of Maithili drama. This commentary is not dialogue from the author's plays but an independent editorial paratext within the volume. It contains claims about the social context of *Adhikar* and institutional inequalities in contemporary theatre; research should read these as editorial perspectives.

Videha's 2012 report of the book launch offers external evidence of the work's circulation at the time. On this basis, it is reasonable to say that the book was present on a public literary platform as well as in print. The available evidence alone cannot establish the venues, number, audience demographics, or responses of all performances; separate production records would be required.

Conclusion

The overall achievement of *Bap Bhel Pitti a Adhikar* is its transformation, within the language of Maithili theatre, of the pain and resistance of people without rights into public scenes. In the first play, children abandoned as though orphaned find the sympathy of people outside their home and preserve their dream of education; in the second, a poor rickshaw puller safeguards his civic dignity amid neglect by village authorities and officials. Both works end happily, but the roads leading there are full of hunger, humiliation, labour, and institutional inequality.

A balanced literary assessment has two levels. In subject matter, Bechan Thakur strongly supports children's education, parental responsibility, social cooperation, opposition to corruption, and awareness of rights. In craft, his distinctive features are vernacular speech, dialogue-driven organisation, songs, symbolic stage objects, and the creation of a public protagonist; his limitations include flat characterisation, extraordinary coincidences, excessive preaching, and the rapid personal resolution of institutional problems.

In the history of children's literature, the first play may appropriately be placed among 'social dramas centred on children's experiences'. Its classification as drama exclusively for children would require additional evidence concerning intended age groups and stage adaptation. The second is not a direct text about children's rights, but can serve as an intellectual resource in civic education for adolescents and young adults. By preserving these generic distinctions, the volume emerges as an important bridge of dialogue between Maithili social theatre and consciousness of justice for children.

04 / 06

Unch-Nich

The Dramatic Conflict of Caste, Education, and Social Equality

Introduction: The Work Under Review, Its Questions, and Its Central Argument

The story of *Unch-Nich* is not merely an external confrontation between two castes. Its inner axis is the difference between social status inherited by birth and human capacity acquired through labour and education. The play asks whether standing in society should be determined by lineage and property or by conduct, work, and knowledge. The playwright seeks an answer first through the everyday lives of a poor couple, then through relationships involving educational institutions and moneylending, and finally through a love marriage and mechanisms of community justice. To restrict the work to an anti-caste message would obscure its economic and dramatic complexity.

The family of Mangal, Marni, and Dukhan forms the text's central axis. Their bamboo work, weaving of baskets and trays, efforts to raise fees, and compulsion to lose farmland and jewellery give the plot its concrete material foundation. Opposite them stand the prosperous household of Chandresh Jha, the aspiration to make his daughter a doctor, profits from moneylending, a hunger for prestige, and caste arrogance. In the final act, the children of the two households meet as adults, and their families' old relationship is tested against new ethical standards.

Bechan Thakur's *Unch-Nich* is a social play published by Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, in 2013. Its three acts contain six, nine, and seven scenes respectively.

The Overall Architecture of the Plot: From Labour to Education and from Education to Rights

In the first act, the family's material deprivation and Marni's thoughtful conduct establish the dramatic problem. Mangal vacillates among the habit of drinking, market prices, his son's studies, and family expectations. Marni seeks

to direct him towards self-restraint, health, and education. Dukhan's difficulty in paying fees creates a moment when livelihood and the future stand face to face. In selling the poor family's handicrafts, the unequal capacities of customers and landowners become brutally apparent. Economic relationships, respectful forms of address, and helpless supplication converge in a single dramatic arrangement.

The second act makes clear the long-term cost of the educational project. Good results bring encouragement, but expenses for the next class, college, training, and engineering education draw the family into a cycle of debt. The daughter of a wealthy household moves towards the city for higher education, while Dukhan's studies raise questions about Marni's jewellery and the family's ancestral homesite. Inequality of access for equally capable students becomes unmistakable. Alongside the older rhythms of domestic life, the new world of the city, college, and employment enters the narrative.

In the third act, educated children challenge the older discipline of caste. Dukhan has become an engineer, while the wealthy family's daughter, having received medical education, seeks the freedom to decide for herself. Love, favouritism in employment, family wishes, fear of social humiliation, and direct violence concentrate the conflict. Finally, a public panchayat turns the private relationship into a matter of communal decision. The happy ending offers hope, but leaves unresolved the restitution of economic losses and the lawful consequences of violence.

Individual Close Readings of the Scenes

Act One, Scene 1: Home and Courtyard, Labour, and a Mother's Reasoning

A conversation beginning as Mangal and Marni weave bamboo baskets and trays reaches questions of health, drinking, family expenditure, and Dukhan's education. Although she has not received formal schooling, Marni connects social advice she has heard with her own life experience. She urges Mangal to reduce his spending on alcohol and consider their son's studies. The scene establishes the play's moral heroism in a mother's reasoning and labour. At the same time, Mangal's preference for sons hints at gender prejudice. Speech within the home here becomes a debate about the distribution of resources rather than a simple sermon. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act One, Scene 2: Fees, Commodities, and Unequal Bargaining

Dukhan's application or study-related fee abruptly pushes the family into financial crisis. They plan to sell the products of their labour—baskets and trays—but Mangal's bargaining power proves weak before the customer. The value of these goods is no longer merely their market price: it becomes the life-price of a child's future. The imbalance between the customer's bargaining and the family's pleading reveals the social power of capital. The play establishes poverty not as the result of laziness but as the outcome of uncertain income and unequal exchange. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act One, Scene 3: The Mansion, Humiliation, and the First Voice of Resistance

Marni reaches Chandresh Jha's mansion hoping to sell her products. A low price, accusations of delay, pressure over outstanding money, and threats to strike a woman intensify together within the scene. Intervention by a young woman in the wealthy household changes the situation. The upper-class home is not represented as homogeneous: the father supports exploitation, while the daughter recognises injustice. The playwright plants the seeds of future anti-caste possibilities in this generational difference. Yet decision-making authority remains immediately centred in the landowner's household; Marni receives temporary recognition for her labour through an intervention within that family rather than her own autonomous power. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act One, Scene 4: Alcohol, Male Company, and a Mother's Burden

On the pretext of looking for Sugar, Mangal is led by Rabiya towards drinking. Distorted speech and behaviour after intoxication, fighting, and Marni's anger make the domestic crisis visible. The scene combines humour with pathos: the uninhibited language of drunkenness makes the audience laugh, but the struggle to raise educational fees recalls its social cost. Marni's conditional forgiveness constructs a moral discipline for the home. If the scene is staged merely as a spectacle of drinking, the family's educational crisis could be obscured. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act One, Scene 5: The Small Drama of Usury

Following Chandresh's private reflection on profit and loss, an account of principal and interest arises with Sitaram. Small sums, arithmetic, and the unequal seating of creditor and debtor present the gestures of everyday exploitation. The satirical distance between Chandresh's religiosity and his greed becomes dense in the text. The scene is effective in exposing the exploitative tendencies concealed within a publicly respected person. Yet Sitaram has little agency; while the playwright shows the mechanisms of economic control, he does not expand on possible collective resistance. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act One, Scene 6: Examinations and the Prelude to Debt

Dukhan's examinations, study materials, and necessary expenditure once again raise the question of family savings. Marni's patient thrift and Mangal's anxiety both complement and conflict with one another. Transactions with Chandresh and the expectation of his favour reveal the poor family's dependence. The first act closes by making readers understand that a capable student's determination alone cannot ensure social mobility: resources must be provided continuously. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 1: The Tea Shop as a Public Space

Jhingur's tea shop becomes an open public stage for discussing inflation, studies, young people's futures, and competition. Conversation among several youths moves the play beyond a single family towards a broader picture of educated rural society. The small question of the price of tea is woven into the

larger question of the education market. The abundance of dialogue expands the social world but also risks slowing the plot. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 2: A Prosperous Daughter and Educational Investment

Chandresh and Manisha celebrate their daughter's educational success. Preparations are made for her to travel to Darbhanga for higher studies. The contrast between daily labour and sales needed to finance Dukhan's education and the secure resources available to the prosperous daughter produces a comparison within the same play. Educating a daughter is a positive aim, but the father's hopes for her future also centre on marital prestige and concern for a socially elevated household. Providing higher education to a daughter does not necessarily mean accepting social equality: this contradiction gives the scene its sharpness. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 3: Further Education Versus a Mother's Inherited Jewellery

Dukhan's results are a cause for happiness, but the family faces uncertain expenses for his further studies. The possibility of pawning Marni's *hansli* necklace, a memento of her parents, generates emotional conflict. Which should take precedence, her son's future or the preservation of maternal memory? The play delicately captures the ethical cost of economic deprivation here. Selling jewellery is not merely a transfer of capital but the displacement of memory across generations. Dukhan's intense desire to study wins readers' sympathy, yet the mother's decision is not free of suffering. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 4: Mortgages and the Distance of Power

Marni takes her necklace to Chandresh. Within the rich man's home, distance, tone, light, and apprehension become the dramatic furnishings of financial power. Loan conditions and high interest transfer poor people's possessions into wealthy hands. Compared with the earlier scene of selling bamboo trays, exploitation has intensified: previously the value of handicrafts was reduced; now an object of family memory becomes collateral. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 5: Admission Fees and the Pressure of Relationships

Mangal and Dukhan await Marni's return. A deadline and late fee turn time into an economic adversary. The money she obtains makes admission possible, but does not remove the family's debt. Later moments of domestic humour keep the scene human, although the larger concern remains access to higher education. The playwright shows readers how time-bound application systems can themselves become barriers for the poor. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 6: The Fear of Control Accompanying Higher Education

In the prosperous family, the decision to send the daughter away to study increases anxieties about prestige and sexual control. A tendency emerges to suspect young women's independence on the basis of news reports. Manisha and Chandresh's dialogue contains inner conflicts of affection, suspicion, marital management, and family honour. The scene indicates that financial means do not automatically secure women's autonomy. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 7: Engineering Education and Impossible Fees

Dukhan declares his ambition to pursue advanced technical education. Mangal tries to understand what he means; the social distance between 'studying' and 'becoming an engineer' is clear. The family's tribal or caste identity is not the decisive issue here; lack of money and information constitutes the more concentrated crisis. Education becomes a project of social mobility, while poverty of resources makes its path uncertain. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 8: The Value of the Homestead and the Politics of Signatures

Discussion of how to finance engineering studies eventually leads to documentary transactions with Chandresh. There is a payment of four lakh rupees involving signatures and thumb impressions. A subsequent soliloquy makes clear that rights over Mangal's ancestral homesite and the necklace have been transferred. This is a crucial turning point: the possibility of educational success is purchased at the cost of becoming landless. The document is not an inert object but a theatrical instrument that creates power. The legal details of the loan conditions are not fully transparent in the text; it would therefore be wrong to describe this relationship as an 'equal exchange undertaken freely'. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Two, Scene 9: The Government Grove and a Displaced Family

Mangal and Marni now live under a makeshift reed shelter in a government grove. Dukhan has obtained admission at a tremendous cost; their temporary residence visibly attests to the historic price of education. Manikant's sympathy, Rabiya's regret over his earlier misconduct, and Marni's insistence on education connect the play with the wider community. The second act ends here: the family is economically depleted yet full of confidence in the future. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Three, Scene 1: A Reunion of Educated Young People

In a new setting, a young woman trained in medicine meets the engineer Dukhan. The conflict between educated minds and the caste distance of the old village community becomes plain. The account of Dukhan's parents losing their land acquaints the young woman with her own father's economic conduct. The possibility of love thus moves beyond attraction towards a shared sense of justice. Yet the inequality of their economic and social backgrounds does not simply disappear. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Three, Scene 2: Bargaining, Patronage, and Caste in Employment

In the railway recruitment episode, Dukhan is confronted with a demand for a large sum and insult on caste grounds. At the same time, Chandresh tries to use social connections and caste ties for his daughter. The play opens different institutional doors for two applicants: one possesses ability but lacks means, while the other possesses contacts. The incident exposes ethical failure in the employment system, but the episode is a satirical social scene rather than a comprehensive institutional record; the distinction must be retained. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Three, Scene 3: Love and Internalised Inferiority

The growing intimacy of Dukhan and the daughter of the prosperous household gradually reaches an acknowledgement of love. Dukhan passes through moments of viewing his own caste status as an obstacle to the relationship; the young woman challenges this sense of inferiority. The scene's dramatic force lies not simply in the declaration of love but in the double voice within a person's mind under social division. Sentimental repetition in the expression of love nevertheless slows the theatrical pace for a time. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Three, Scene 4: An Educated Daughter and the Barrier of Family Prestige

When discussion of marriage begins at home, the young woman argues for a decision founded upon equality and personal wishes. Her father treats lineage, caste, and prestige as supreme. Although Manisha initially appears relatively sympathetic, she too becomes apprehensive upon learning Dukhan's caste. The play grasps an important truth: theoretical liberalism and practical liberalism when marriage enters one's own family are different things. The medically trained young woman's personality emerges as intellectually independent. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Three, Scene 5: From Caste Humiliation to Organised Violence

Chandresh's pride and fear for his reputation turn into anger. Memories of earlier financial transactions that enabled Dukhan's education are recast as arrogant claims of 'benevolence'. A confrontation and beating involving accomplices become an extreme performance of caste power. The narrative moves from an argument resembling nonviolent resistance into physical violence. An important question for readers is whether justice after such violence can remain confined to private reconciliation or requires a formal structure of accountability. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Three, Scene 6: The Meaning of Education and the Search for Community Justice

After the beating, the wounded Dukhan expresses his love and opposition to caste discrimination. Marni's maternal anxiety, Mangal's patience, and Manikant's good judgement appear together. The decision moves not towards immediate revenge but towards collective deliberation and the panchayat. Education is redefined here not merely as a means to employment but as a critical consciousness of social equality. Yet the dialogue sometimes becomes speechmaking, diminishing the subtlety of inner psychological states. (Thakur, 2013.)

Act Three, Scene 7: The Panchayat, Equality, and the Limits of a Happy Ending

The panchayat gathered in the school grounds makes a private dispute a public question of justice. Sarpanch Motilal hears the Dalit character's case, insists upon merit and human dignity rather than caste and wealth, and decides in favour of the marriage. Chandresh's acceptance, the exchange of

garlands, the meeting of the fathers-in-law, and collective blessings bring the play to an end. The scene creates the communal festive feeling of folk theatre; Rabiya's humorous subplot relaxes the narrative tension. Yet the final settlement does not clearly resolve punishment for the beating, correction of the unequal economic deal, or restoration of the land lost by the Dalit family. The result is thus an idealised happy ending of equality, not factual proof that complete social justice has been achieved. (Thakur, 2013.)

Character Analysis: Contradictions, Aspirations, and Actions

Marni: Informal Knowledge, Labour, and Moral Resolve

To make Marni merely an emblem of the self-sacrificing mother would diminish her dramatic agency. She questions Mangal's drinking, applies ideas about health heard from others, gathers resources for her son's education, bargains with customers at the market, protests against humiliation, and ultimately risks the jewellery inherited in memory of her parents. Her actions signify that a woman's knowledge is not determined solely by school certificates. Labour, experience, and the capacity to reason become the household's principal intellectual resources.

There is nevertheless a danger in the image of the 'generous mother'. The play repeatedly expects limitless sacrifice from Marni's family role. Her independent wish to preserve her body, memories, property, and emotions becomes subordinate to her child's aspirations. A feminist rereading would ask whether glorifying a poor mother's sacrifice is the same thing as granting just social recognition to her labour. It is not.

Mangal: Fatherhood, Weakness, and Changing Responsibility

Mangal is not a consistently virtuous, one-dimensional character. Drinking, patriarchal speech, disorganised decisions, and his association with Rabiya are among his weaknesses. On the other hand, saving for his son's studies, continuing to work, worrying about his family, and seeking a considered communal solution in the final act are emerging signs of responsibility. This duality makes him a believable rural character. The limits of his self-respect are particularly significant: he bows before commercial customers but stands firm when his son's development is at stake.

Dukhan: A Narrative of Talent and the Contradictions of Social Mobility

Dukhan's journey leads from a student unable to pay his fees to an engineer. This trajectory encompasses childhood labour, education in youth, and adult self-determination. Yet his achievement is not an individualistic story of 'work hard and anything is possible'. His mother's jewellery, the surrender of the homestead, and the displacement of the family constitute the collective price of success. Applying the question of high and low status to intimate relationships in the third act signifies his critical maturity. Dukhan rebels against society's standards, although at certain turning points his agency remains defined by the public panchayat's decision.

Chandresh Jha: Appropriation Under the Guise of Benevolence

Chandresh wants to accumulate wealth, command public respect, give his daughter the finest education, and preserve the prestige of his lineage. His complacent outlook reduces the daily difficulties of poor people to questions of higher prices or overdue payments. He is a wealthy father, but not a just father of society. His daughter's demand for autonomy in choosing a spouse reveals the limits of his authority. The character matters not because he is simply a 'bad person', but because the advantages of a hierarchical society accumulate in a person who regards his conduct as normal. His final change of heart offers emotional relief, but does not readily erase the consequences of earlier exploitation.

The Educated Young Woman, Manisha, and Generational Differences Among Women

The young woman of the wealthy family seeks both medical training and the right to decide upon her life partner. Her father treats his financial investment as a basis for controlling marriage; she treats education as the basis of ethical autonomy. Manisha's behaviour is more complex: she sometimes softens the father's anger but cannot free herself from inherited prejudice when her daughter crosses the caste boundary. In this triangle, the play questions the notion that women's experiences are uniform.

Manikant, Motilal, Rabiya, and the Supporting Community

Manikant represents the judgement of a mediator, Motilal public decision-making, and Rabiya the flow of folk humour. Manikant listens to the suffering of working people and provides opportunities for dialogue. Motilal turns the panchayat into a public forum for justice, though the question remains how far his decisions depend on personal generosity. Rabiya creates humour and offers Mangal a contrasting choice in matters of drinking. Such humour requires care: the identities of Dalit or working-class characters should not be turned into material for mockery alone.

A Closer Analysis of Social Questions

Caste and Class: Two Distinct but Interconnected Powers

The words 'high' and 'low' in the title refer not merely to social forms of address but to a system for distributing resources. Who will perform productive labour, who will determine prices, who will be made to accept loan conditions, whose education will be straightforward, and whose marriage will be called respectable? These five distinct questions are interwoven in the same caste-class relationship. Even becoming an engineer does not instantly remove the stigma of Dukhan's previous social standing. He faces discrimination both in employment and in love. In this sense, 'merit' does not automatically destroy caste; the events of the play reveal the additional necessity of changing the structure of social institutions.

The playwright nevertheless often concentrates class analysis upon the greed of a particular wealthy man. The narrative ends with Chandresh's personal generosity and the panchayat's acceptance. If caste is an institutional form of unequal land rights, hierarchy, and prestige, one marriage cannot constitute its ultimate solution. This difference is a productive critical tension between the play's ideal and its social reality.

The Progressive Displacement of Labour, Possessions, and Land

The economic subplot begins with bamboo baskets and trays, advances to the *hansli* necklace, and then takes the form of selling the ancestral homesite. The sequence of objects creates the play's political economy: daily production → savings → inherited jewellery → house and land → temporary reed shelter. Throughout this sequence, the family loses material assets while accumulating educational capital for its child. The playwright does not diminish the importance of educational achievement; he shows that its cost is doubled for marginalised families, who must pay fees and bear social risks. Growing wealth in Chandresh's household and diminishing immovable property in Mangal's household establish parallel visual sequences.

Education: The Hope of Liberation and Institutional Inequality

Fees and examination dates impede Dukhan at school; large payments impede him in college; patronage and demands for bribes impede him in employment. Education gives him intellectual ability, but the old caste-class system meets him at the next door. The prosperous daughter benefits from higher education but struggles against caste-based control over marriage within her home. The comparison of these two educational journeys is illuminating: education offers liberation to both a woman and a Dalit young man, yet the opponents of liberation return in different forms.

Patriarchy, Women's Agency, and Love Marriage

The family's economic crisis limits Marni's right to decide. The educated young woman's father limits her right to decide through family prestige. Although they belong to different classes, the two women are united in a struggle for autonomy. The love-marriage plot breaks a caste boundary, but women's rights should not be confined to the choice of a lover. Professional futures, fears of violence against their bodies, rights over family property, and participation in public society are also at issue. The play indicates these questions without giving full development to each.

Religion, Display, and Economic Ethics

The distance between the wealthy character's religious practices and his harsh treatment of the poor generates satire. Religious pilgrimage or worship is no evidence of exemption from social responsibility: this idea emerges within the contradictions of Chandresh's greed. The play does not mount a wholesale attack on religious belief; it reveals the ethical incongruity of conduct. It is therefore more faithful to the evidence to read it as moral satire.

Dramatic Craft, Theatrical Language, and Performability

Bechan Thakur's writing is scene-based, dialogue-driven, and animated by the small objects and circumstances of rural life. Handicrafts, chairs, diaries, papers, signatures, jewellery, rupees, reed shelters, schools, and panchayat seating repeatedly become meaningful stage properties. The purposeful sequence of objects can communicate social distance to spectators without extensive explanation. Mangal's working hands and the comfortable seat in Chandresh's verandah, for example, could create an effective opposition within a single stage arrangement.

The dialogue is rooted in local life through its exclamations and idioms. Ordinary conversation turns towards an economic or moral issue. Marni's questions and answers, Mangal's drunken inconsistencies, Rabiya's humour, Chandresh's commanding speech, and Motilal's panchayat proclamations construct distinct social voices. In the third act, the contrast between Maithili and Hindi-speaking administrative dialogue in the employment scene becomes an audible sign of social domination.

The limitations of form must also be identified. Many scenes rely on characters directly announcing ethical principles, and repetition of the same proposition reduces the complexity of their internal struggles. Some long conversations in the second act, the declaration of love in the third, and the final panchayat speech might need precise editing for performance. Criticism of the published text and proposals for theatrical abbreviation are, however, separate processes; the original work must be preserved intact as an archival text.

Humour in the play can expose relationships of social power. If the jokes about alcohol or Rabiya's hunger are exaggerated in performance, they could diminish the seriousness of oppression; restrained acting would make the contradiction more meaningful. Respectful representation of female characters, critical framing of caste insults, avoidance of romanticising violence, and balanced positioning of actors at the panchayat would be central concerns of stage direction.

The expansion of time is significant: the protagonist ages from primary schooling to professional employment. The three-act structure permits this temporal breadth, but stage lighting, sound, and acting must make clear the passage of time between scenes, sustain the audience's patience, and register the characters' maturation. In this sense, *Unch-Nich* moves readily between the printed page and the popular stage, though it demands sensitive editing.

The History of Maithili Children's Literature: A Comparative Discussion

From Oral Literature for Infants to Written Genres

Phulchandra Jha 'Praveen's' *Maithili Shishu Lok Sahitya* (Videha, issue 50, 2010) emphasises the oral transmission of nursery songs and folk traditions. It

distinguishes oral literature used in child-rearing, play and entertainment, and the acquisition of knowledge. This tradition views the family as the first school of a child's socialisation. Mangal and Marni's home in *Unch-Nich* presents a modern form of this traditional site of folk knowledge, but its primary objective is not the entertainment of infants. It concerns school certificates, social inequality, and civic standing. Thus, although the two genres share source environments, their purposes for readers differ.

Yoganand Jha's *Maithili Bal-Lokkatha: Sthiti a Apeksha* (Videha, issue 76, 2011) provides examples of interest in stories, accessible language, knowledge, and entertainment. It demonstrates the importance of retaining the original language when collecting folktales. This model helps us understand the literary value of the rural speech in *Unch-Nich*, but the concise suspense of a folktale and the prolonged social conflict of this drama are not the same kind of text.

Picture Stories, Children's Drama, and a Visual Tradition of Dalit Protagonists

Durganand Mandal's 2012 Videha article *Nena Lel Sundar Chitrakatha* praises Preeti Thakur's picture stories for bringing folk figures such as Gonu Jha, Salhes, Dina-Bhadri, and Chhechhan to a new generation. The review mentions socially marginalised protagonists and stories of inter-caste love. The similarity here is significant: Dukhan in *Unch-Nich* is a modern educated Dalit protagonist, while several picture stories raise questions of human dignity through folk memory and folk heroes. The genres and modes of presentation differ, but their cultural effort to choose protagonists who challenge dominant models is comparable.

Videha's book catalogue lists Munna Ji's *Tin Ta Bal Natak* separately under 'Maithili Children's Literature', whereas Bechan Thakur's *Unch-Nich* is explicitly listed as a 'play'. This cataloguing is itself useful evidence of genre. The presence of child characters alone is not sufficient to classify a work as children's drama. A feasible performance by child actors, limited duration, age-appropriate depiction of violence, children's active minds, accessible language, and a development of characters grounded in their experience are also expected. On these grounds, *Unch-Nich* can be useful to adolescent audiences through selected scenes, but in its entirety it is a broad social drama.

Contemporary Criticism and the Expanding Boundaries of Children's Literature

Videha's research index records an essay titled *Maithili Balnatak Sima Vistar Karait—Chauari* by Ramesh Ranjan (issue 126, 2013). The record points to the existence of a distinct critical vocabulary for children's drama; because of discrepancies between the page heading and its contents, no specific ideological proposition has been attributed to the essay without textual support. *Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra*, published in 2026, extends the critical language of children's agency, caste representation, folk narratives, and appropriateness. This later debate may be applied to the work of 2013 with

proper historical caution; the influence of present-day theory on an earlier author cannot be assumed. [5, 6]

Three conclusions emerge from the comparison. First, the life of the student Dukhan in *Unch-Nich* is particularly useful for studying children's and educational rights. Second, the dramatic depiction of caste-based humiliation allows adolescent spectators to ask difficult questions about social inequality. Third, adult drinking, physical violence, usurious transactions, long-term love, and panchayat decisions prevent the work from becoming an ordinary introductory children's play. Its audience should therefore be determined by age and educational purpose rather than by reversing the author's generic identification.

Bechan Thakur's Theatrical Tradition and Videha's Critical Context

In his 2011 review *Bechan Thakurjik Natak Chhinar Devi*, Ashish Anchinhar examines the playwright's stage direction, village performance traditions, and opposition to social superstition. He identifies the performance-oriented nature of Thakur's plays and the mutual relationship of literature and theatre. This earlier review provides a historical background for reading *Unch-Nich*: Thakur's drama is not writing confined to a book, but social literature connected to the possibilities of popular performance. Nevertheless, the subject of *Chhinar Devi* differs from *Unch-Nich*'s debate about education, caste, and property. It would be wrong to assume thematic uniformity between the two works.

Discussions of Dalit literary aesthetics and new approaches to dramatic criticism published in Videha provide a contemporary vocabulary for criticising hierarchy and examining stage performance in Maithili. This context makes it possible to read the play's protagonists not as poor people receiving pity but as claimants to social rights. Later critical works, however, are treated as comparative instruments rather than decisive evidence of the play's authentic meaning. [8, 9]

Critical Achievements and Limitations of the Text

The first achievement is the visual presentation of class differences. When the workshop-like surroundings of Mangal's home, where baskets are woven, and Chandresh's comfortable verandah occupy the same social geography, the title *Unch-Nich* acquires material meaning. The second is Marni's agency: she is the first organiser of the family's responsibilities and the first source of social reasoning in difficult times. The third is the portrayal of the long-term costs of education: a child's future is not merely a personal aspiration but an investment of labour across generations. The fourth is the disproportionate relationship between economic transformation and caste inequality: the son becomes an engineer, but caste again appears at the doors of relationships and employment.

A fifth achievement is the theatrical use of the public panchayat. Its meeting in a school compound is a powerful symbol of place: where education teaches the skill of raising social questions, social justice is debated. A sixth achievement is the contradiction between the modernity of a father who wants to educate his daughter and the old impulse to defend lineage that is terrified of an inter-caste marriage.

The first limitation is repeated preaching. Many exchanges make the theoretical argument for social reform explicit, but the characters' natural experience sometimes remains merely a carrier of ideas. The second is the simplification of the consequences of violence. An organised assault upon Dukhan is a grave injustice; the panchayat then promptly resolves the matter through marriage, without extended treatment of criminal accountability, safe rehabilitation for the victim, or institutional injustice. The third is the incomplete treatment of property: an unequal transaction resembling the seizure of the homesite and necklace does not automatically become just through personal reconciliation.

A fourth limitation is the marriage-centred definition of women's freedom. Although the medically trained young woman is an educated citizen, her professional life and long-term autonomy can become secondary in the happy ending. A fifth is the limited visibility of collective Dalit organisation: the protagonist's individual talent and courage in love receive more attention than a programme of collective reform. Such criticism does not deny the play's historical contribution; rather, it identifies the limits of its morally directed happy ending.

Possibilities for Educational and Theatrical Use

At senior secondary and university levels, selected scenes from this play could support discussions of economic inequality, the dignity of labour, educational access, caste prejudice, consent in marriage, and community justice. Teaching the domestic debate between Mangal and Marni alongside Chandresh's market scene could help students understand how a family's desire for education is affected by inequalities in the marketplace. The sequence of necklace, homesite, and reed shelter in the second act offers an opportunity to teach the visual grammar of rights over resources. Employment and panchayat episodes in the third act can clarify the difference between institutional justice and private reconciliation.

For a complete stage production, it would be useful to clarify the leaps in time between acts, balance repetitive dialogue, perform caste insults sensitively, control the staging of violence, and open the unresolved questions of economic justice to audience discussion after the final decision. A production involving students must present violent and adult episodes in ways appropriate to their ages. The purpose of such experimentation is not to rewrite the original text's language but to understand the different levels of its social thinking.

Epilogue

The significance of *Unch-Nich* lies in making a poor family's journey through education a fundamental question of Mithila's social hierarchy. Mangal and Marni's labour, Dukhan's thirst for higher education, Chandresh's system of accumulated wealth, and the young woman's support for self-determination together construct a social triangle: knowledge, property, and respect. The play repeatedly demonstrates that education gives people abilities, but society still needs to learn the cultural practice of respecting those abilities. This is its moral achievement.

The critical conclusion is more exacting. The marriage union is certainly a symbolic victory over caste division, but it does not fully remedy the appropriation of land, pressure of debt, favouritism in employment, and physical violence. The play is therefore not a record of the completion of social justice but a work that forcefully stages its necessity. Its meaningful relationship with the history of Maithili children's literature lies in the question of education and young people's agency, while its original generic identity as adult social drama remains intact. Through such a differentiated, evidence-based reading, *Unch-Nich* provides Maithili literature with an important theatrical expression of social life shaped by caste and class.

05 / 06

Biswasghat

The Breakdown of Trust, Land Acquisition, and Popular Justice

Introduction: The Literary Questions Raised by the Play

The title *Biswasghat* ('Betrayal') announces its subject. Trust is not merely a private virtue but the foundation of social conduct: a brother's trust in a brother, the acceptance of advice between husband and wife, the relation of rights between father and son, the citizen's faith in administration, and society's trust in institutions of justice. The play presents the breaking of trust at each of these levels. An event involving monetary compensation does not remain a private property dispute; it becomes a public drama of the unequal distribution of power and wealth.

This text is a play, not a novel or a children's story. The printed copyright page also states in English, 'Biswasghat, Play by Bechan Thakur'. Its formal foundations are dialogue attributed to named characters, acting directions in parentheses, entrances and exits, curtain falls, and divisions into acts and scenes. The primary basis for this review is therefore not plot summary but the relationship between events and actions represented onstage.

The principal questions of this critical reading are these: how does the play show familial trust becoming a shield for corruption? To what extent does a

resistant young man become an ethical ideal? How are the judgement and voices of female characters rejected? And what contradiction remains between lawful justice and the use of administrative force in the final resolution?

Three Acts of the Story: From Trust to Justice

Act One: Trust Transformed into the Power of Documents

The first scene presents the affectionate atmosphere of tea shared by three brothers. Ram Kishun, Lakhan, and Siyaram consider a notice concerning land acquisition for a road. Displaying his government connections, Ram Kishun asks his brothers to hand over their documents. Here trust ceases to be merely verbal reassurance and becomes the material act of surrendering papers of ownership. The second scene presents the caution of Lakhan's wife, Lakshmi. She advises him to consult knowledgeable people before handing over the land documents, but Lakhan dismisses her advice as 'a woman's words'. The first foreshadowing of the later catastrophe lies in her being ignored.

A Holi gathering and feast, hospitality extended to officers over tea, the land acquisition office, and transactions with an engineer establish bribery not as one entirely secret crime but as an extension of social contacts. The fifth scene is particularly decisive: on the basis of original compensation amounts of eighty thousand rupees for Lakhan, one lakh for Siyaram, and one lakh forty thousand for Ram Kishun, the total was three lakh twenty thousand. Through the engineer's manipulation, these become eight, ten, and fourteen lakh respectively, amounting to thirty-two lakh rupees. The engineer demands eight lakh in advance; subsequent transactions involve the cooperation of a land acquisition employee and a peon.

Documentary evidence and the correctness of the amounts disappear in the secret exchange of bribes. Concealing the actual payments from his brothers, Ram Kishun gives Lakhan fifty thousand rupees and Siyaram seventy thousand. He performs a role of failed endeavours, an intractable government system, and benevolent assistance. Ramlal detects the discrepancy by bringing together newspaper reports, office records, and differences in amounts. He represents the conflict within a new generation between obedience to elders and rational verification.

Towards the end of the first act, the court of Sarpanch Gangaram rejects Ramlal's claim because of a supposed lack of evidence and the non-cooperation of his father, Lakhan. The matter then reaches the home: Lakhan's domestic violence, Ramlal's violent response, and the forcible taking of a thumb impression on blank paper give the struggle for rights moral complexity even when its cause is on the victim's side.

Act Two: Institutional Access and the Murder of Resistance

In the second act, Lakhan takes shelter with Ram Kishun because he fears his own son. Ramlal's petition reaches the sub-divisional officer and district officer, from whom instructions for an inquiry are sent to the police station.

But the station repeatedly becomes a place of transactions instead of complaints. The employees responsible for investigation convert police authority into pressure, demands for hospitality, and financial bargaining.

District officer Bijendra initially appears to be relatively willing to investigate, while Ram Kishun tries to suppress the complaint through his political and police connections. As the pressure increases, however, Ram Kishun uses an associate named Bir to arrange Ramlal's murder through the gang led by the criminal Raja. The plan, advance payment, deception, and murder are the play's most horrifying events. Ramlal is led away from the tea shop under the guise of friendship. The innocent young man appeals to the morality of his killers, but he is murdered.

This violence transforms the struggle. Its object is no longer simply the division of compensation but the truth about a crime and justice for the dead. Lakshmi's maternal grief, the concerns of the younger son Jhamlal, the initiative of their maternal uncle Lakshman, and the responses of village residents gradually take the form of collective resistance. The playwright constructs this change not merely to increase the number of incidents but as the public consequence of a private struggle.

Act Three: Society, Administration, and Incomplete Restitution

In the third act, Lakshman and Jhamlal convene a community meeting. After the failure of the first panchayat, facts and public participation gain strength in the second; Lakhan's plight and Ramlal's murder become matters of collective judgement. Ram Kishun resists the community's proposal for compensation, and the conflict extends to a protest and intervention by higher administration.

The portrayal of administrative process is itself full of contradictions. The actions of officials and police include examining records and arresting criminals, but also degrading beatings and unconstitutional forms of punishment. The tendency to count the death of the criminal gang as an achievement of dramatic resolution raises questions. Praising punishment without respect for law and judicial hearings must be reckoned among the play's critical limitations.

At the public hearing, responsibility is fixed upon four people: Ram Kishun is to pay five lakh rupees, Bir one lakh, engineer Uma Shankar two lakh, and land acquisition employee Sushil two lakh—a total of ten lakh rupees to Lakhan. In the final scene, the money is handed over and Ram Kishun apologises. Yet the ultimate sorrow is not money but Ramlal's absence. Treating murder, manipulation of public funds, and accountability of criminals and administrators as resolved solely through private forgiveness or local financial settlement is insufficient in legal terms. The play itself allows these undecided questions to be raised.

The Title, Symbolism, and the Dramatic Meaning of Objects

The central irony of *Biswasghat* is that trust and deception flourish within the same relationship. Ram Kishun's modest speech and apparent service stand opposed to his private calculations. Lakhan's blind trust cannot simply be dismissed as personal stupidity: family seniority, social prestige, fear of government offices, and unfamiliarity with legal processes combine to make him vulnerable.

Paper is the play's central stage object. First come original land documents, then notices, revised amounts, cheques, official registers, petitions, panchayat notices, thumb impressions on blank sheets, and finally decisions. Every document establishes or undermines someone's ownership or the legitimacy of a claim. Trust formerly resting on oral relationships confronts the power of written evidence and official records. In this sense, the work has features of 'documentary drama', even though its formal construction is traditionally dialogue-driven.

Tea and hospitality recur throughout the play. Initially, tea marks the brothers' fellowship; later, tea with an officer becomes a preparation for proposing a bribe. Hospitality offered to police and intermediaries becomes an instrument for agreements involving power. Before the murder, Bir takes Ramlal away from a tea stall. Through this gradual transformation in the meaning of the same object, the play suggests betrayal concealed within everyday life.

Amounts such as eighty thousand, eight lakh, fifty thousand, and five lakh are not mere numerical details. The arithmetic of money anchors the relations of power: a person who can read documents, access official files, and buy the services of office employees increases his own share. Economic injustice therefore arises not solely from the price of land but also from inequalities of knowledge and access.

Character Analysis: Beyond One-Dimensional Heroes and Villains

Ram Kishun: The Performance of Generosity and the Violence of Accounting

Ram Kishun is constructed on two levels. Outwardly, he is a respectful, sociable brother who offers refreshments and knows officials. Inwardly, his aim is financial gain, control of evidence, and suppression of challenges. This duality can be theatrically effective because, after a few scenes, the audience knows the truth about him while Lakhan and Siyaram remain in the dark. The centre of dramatic irony lies precisely here.

Ram Kishun is not merely a greedy businessman behind the crime but someone who exploits flaws in the system. He collaborates with the engineer, bribes office employees, bargains with police misconduct, and finally orders a murder. Yet his remorse at the end appears as a sudden moral transformation. The question is not whether a criminal can reform, but whether, after such

grave violence, public shame and an oath can credibly be regarded as sufficient atonement.

Lakhan and Siyaram: Victims of Trust, but Not Exempt from the Duty to Reason

Lakhan's innocence is both pitiable and open to criticism. He refuses to hear the reasoning of the woman in his home, denies his son's information, and avoids checking facts. He then commits domestic violence against his wife. His victimhood thus does not prove his moral innocence. Siyaram's role mainly consists of agreement, delayed doubt, and small hopes. Both characters indicate that defending social rights demands independent examination alongside kinship ties.

Ramlal: The Courage of Rights, Excessive Anger, and Martyrdom

Ramlal questions the arithmetic of the fraud, reads newspapers, visits offices, and files petitions. It is appropriate to call him a bearer of modern civic reason. His behaviour, however, is not entirely nonviolent. His attack upon his father while protecting his mother, his forcible taking of a mark on blank paper, and his angry speeches prevent him from becoming an unambiguous ideal. The author reveals the importance of his courage; criticism must also examine the violence accompanying that courage.

Ramlal's murder is the ethical breaking point of the text. His appeal to the murderers' 'honesty' before death is an extreme form of the language of resistance. Yet to describe a young man's death merely as 'the price of trust' would forget his claim to citizenship while alive. Jhamlal and Lakshman take his place in the final act, but Ramlal's autonomous voice survives only in memory.

Lakshmi, Jhamlal, and Lakshman: From an Ignored Warning to Social Leadership

Lakshmi initially embodies practical reason. She advises Lakhan to understand the official papers before handing them over, but patriarchal decision-making rejects her. She subsequently suffers domestic violence and the murder of her son, while urging the family towards public justice. Maternal grief is important, but a woman's political intelligence must not be hidden behind her tears. This is an essential feminist rereading of the text.

In his brother's absence, Jhamlal worries about education, livelihood, and social participation. Lakshman's arrival increases the narrative's capacity for organisation. He transforms a personal complaint into a public meeting, a protest, and evidence-based demands before district administration. Yet decisive authority is again surrendered to a powerful male official. The tension between the achievement of popular organisation and protection by the state is an important question in the final act.

Administrative Characters: A Corrupt System and the Problem of the Ideal Officer

Sushil, Uma Shankar, police employees, officials with political connections, and the sarpanch are not identical figures, but relations of power and money recur among them. District officer Bijendra poses a particular problem: he hears complaints and understands the meaning of documents, yet endorses police beatings and extrajudicial punishment. This contradiction prevents the play from fitting into a simple scheme of 'honest officer versus corrupt society'.

Dialogue, Dialect, Time, and Theatrical Structure

Dialogue is the play's principal strength. Conversations among family members contain Maithili intimacy, reproach, and bitterness; the police station and offices have a mixed bureaucratic idiom, Hindi-influenced sentences, and commanding tones; the criminal gang speaks in threats and boasts. These social and linguistic differences make distinct power relationships audible on one stage. Yet long lectures by certain characters also turn dialogue away from living confrontation into something resembling a manifesto.

The span of three acts and forty scenes reveals the complexity of the social milieu. Fragmented locations—verandahs, porches, tea stalls, land acquisition offices, police stations, sarpanch meetings, district headquarters, criminals' dens, and community halls—form a multilayered map of social drama. Yet repeated entrances and exits, changes of curtain, and lengthy office conversations would make timing, scenic coordination, and pace challenging in a complete production.

The work does not merely report violence in the background; its stage directions prescribe direct beatings and murder. Alongside the impact associated with traditional folk theatre arise questions of modern staging: should terrible violence be shown directly, or suggested through sound, light, offstage action, and reactions? Appropriate theatrical design could make these events powerful; excessively explicit violence might turn the social questions into sensationalism.

At the level of humour, tea-seller Lalu's repeated 'mane je', conversations at the police station, and official formalities provide pauses in the action. After Ramlal's murder, however, unnecessary jokes or the spectacle of beatings might undermine the tragic effect. Balanced editing is possible for stage adaptation, but these incidents must not be omitted from a complete study of the original text.

Political Economy, Power, Caste and Class, and Citizenship

The land acquisition episode presents an underlying truth of modern development: a road is considered a public amenity, yet its construction displaces someone's ancestral home, fields, dwelling, and social stability. Compensation in such circumstances is not merely a price but a means of

rehabilitating displaced lives. The play extends the issue beyond buying and selling land to questions of building homes, repaying debts, establishing families, and educating children.

Access to power in the narrative is created through intimacy, drinking parties, personal connections, and exchanges of money. Corruption is not a defect of one isolated character but becomes a network of institutions. Its social effects fall most heavily on the poor: those without independent lawyers, documentary proof, or access to office records must pay for 'trust' with everything they own.

In the other direction, popular organisation and written applications constitute the play's democratic energy. Ramlal's letters and Lakshman's public meetings indicate that, without evidence, public support, and written records, the humiliated citizen's voice may be suppressed. Yet the state's delivery of justice must itself remain within the law. The play suggests that a stern administrator can deliver moral justice; a critical reading asks how the poor can ultimately be secure when their rights lie in the hands of a violent official.

Justice, Punishment, and the Ambiguity of the Ending

The final public hearing offers a scene of economic redress. The ten-lakh-rupee liability of four wrongdoers is established before society, and payment takes place in the presence of witnesses. Theatrically, this gives the satisfaction of a 'decision made in full view'. But the offences—artificial inflation of public compensation, bribery, abuse of documents, contract killing, and murder—each raise questions of independent investigation, lawful prosecution, and the victim family's rights. A financial agreement cannot replace all these processes.

Beating suspects to extract confessions, eliminating an alleged criminal gang without judicial process, and turning an official into the person who dispenses punishment are matters for serious criticism in the theory of justice. The author's intention may be justice opposed to corruption, but limits on the means used are essential to justice itself. An appropriate social solution requires not merely punishment but a transparent process for establishing guilt, rehabilitation of actual victims, and future institutional reform.

Lakhan's final question is the strongest human question of all: compensation cannot bring his son back to life. This line preserves incompleteness within the play's idealistic ending. Ram Kishun's public apology closes the scene emotionally, but to assume that one 'apology' immediately restores trust would diminish the weight of the play's own events. Its finest critical meaning is not that everything is finally well, but that, once social trust has broken, even economic justice cannot undo the irreparable loss of relationships.

Comparative Contexts in Maithili Theatre and Children's Literature

In the study of Maithili theatre, *Biswasghat* should be read as a long, socially realistic play about corruption and rural life. Videha issue 82 (15 May 2011) contains a review by Ashish Anchinhar of Bechan Thakur's *Chhinar Devi*. There, the critic discusses the playwright's involvement in rural theatre and the play's social questions. This independent reference helps us see continuity in Thakur's theatrical interests and social concerns, but it does not establish that the subjects of *Chhinar Devi* and *Biswasghat* are identical.

Videha's research index records Ramesh Ranjan's *Maithili Balnatak Sima Vistar Karait—Chauari* (issue 126, 2013) as part of the discussion of children's drama. Phulchandra Jha 'Praveen's' *Maithili Shishu Lok Sahitya* (issue 50, 2010), Yoganand Jha's *Maithili Bal-Lokkatha: Sthiti a Apeksha* (issue 76, 2011), and Durganand Mandal's *Nena Lel Sundar Chitrakatha* (issue 116, 2012) establish the distinct generic presence of folklore, picture stories, and children's plays within literature for children. These examples are not a complete chronology but documented representative stages available in Videha.

One criterion of children's literature is to shape language and curiosity in accordance with children's experiential worlds. Another is suitability in terms of violence, fear, intellectual complexity, and presentation. *Biswasghat* contains domestic beatings, murder, bribery, criminal gangs, excessively long bureaucratic dialogue, and legal disputes. It would therefore be a generic error to call it children's reading or children's drama without adaptation. Selected episodes, however—understanding a document before signing, verification, the value of education, social assistance, and awareness of rights—could be used in civic education for adolescents.

Gajendra Thakur's *Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra* in Videha issue 447 (August 2026) discusses the multilayered structure of genres for children. This comparative reference is used not to turn *Biswasghat* into a children's novel but to distinguish children's perspectives and age-appropriate texts from adult social drama. If this storyline is adapted for children's theatre, it would be essential to condense events, suggest violence indirectly, emphasise collective decisions and the active reasoning of female characters, and discuss lawful justice.

In writing the history of Maithili children's literature, oral folk traditions, magazine experiments, picture stories, children's songs, children's plays, and modern children's novels may be connected, but their differences of genre should not be erased. This play by Bechan Thakur is not a 'direct text for children' in that history; it is a social reference work of adult theatre. Its relevance to children's literary history extends only to discussion of generic boundaries and possible adaptations for adolescents.

Achievements and Limitations: Critical Conclusions

The play's first achievement is its representation of corruption through small transactions and social hospitality. Its second is the bringing together of a farming family, domestic women, educated young people, intermediaries, police, engineers, employees, and village society into one dramatic map. Its third is the social credibility created through the precise arithmetic of payments and questions of evidence. Its fourth is that Lakhan's regret becomes an experience of human emptiness deeper than economic compensation.

The limitations are also important. Some events depend too heavily on coincidence and an exceptionally powerful officer; many scenes repeat the same message; and the morality of one or two characters seems to change suddenly to suit the story. Ramlal's commitment to truth cannot remove criticism of his violent conduct; Bijendra's opposition to corruption does not legitimise his punitive violence; and Ram Kishun's apology cannot replace accountability before the law.

Taken as a whole, *Biswasghat* may be regarded as a Maithili social play that produces a dramatic confrontation among broken trust, the machinery of the state, the political economy of development, and the sense of justice. Its significance for readers lies not merely in criminals receiving punishment but in keeping alive the question of how far private trust, documentary evidence, collective public strength, and the limits of judicial authority can support—or oppose—one another.

The Emotional Force of Dialogue

> 'I have complete faith in Ram Kishun.' — Lakhan, Act One, Scene Two.
>
> 'I can increase the rate on the notice by up to ten times.' — Uma Shankar, Act One, Scene Five.
>
> 'I will go to the office, I will go, I will go.' — Ramlal, end of Act One, Scene Nine.
>
> 'No wealth in the world is greater than education.' — Lakshman, Act Three, Scene Nine.
>
> 'I have received a great deal of money. But will that money bring my son back?' — Lakhan, Act Three, Scene Nine.

These five quotations preserve, as far as possible, the small variations of pronunciation and spelling in their published forms. The standardised spelling of the critical prose in the original study has not been imposed upon the speakers' quoted words.

A Sequential Examination of Forty Scenes

The narrative content and dramatic function of each scene are examined separately and briefly below.

Act One: Scene-by-Scene Discussion

Scene 1: The three brothers converse over tea and discuss the acquisition notice. Ram Kishun's proposal to take charge of the documents is the first dramatic point of trust.

Scene 2: Lakshmi advises understanding the documents before handing them over; Lakhan's disregard of a woman's advice is linked to subsequent loss.

Scene 3: The Holi celebration brings together a police officer, lawyer, and intermediary. An intimate feast prepares the ground for administrative protection.

Scene 4: At a tea shop, there is a conversation with land acquisition employee Sushil. The proposed bribe is presented as legitimate through sympathy for deprivation and an appeal to practicality.

Scene 5: Engineer Uma Shankar fixes the price for increasing compensation tenfold. The precise arithmetic of the sums forms the economic foundation of the plot.

Scene 6: Bribes to Sushil and peon Bindeshwar accompany the cheque process. The office file becomes a mask of legality for crime.

Scene 7: Ramlal learns about the payments from a newspaper. The generational dispute between father and son becomes a question of knowledge versus obedience.

Scene 8: Through refreshments and tea, Ram Kishun reinforces his brothers' trust; Ramlal is described as hasty.

Scene 9: Ram Kishun presents false accounts; Ramlal resolves to investigate the office records.

Scene 10: After encountering bribery at the office, information emerges about the actual payments of eight, ten, and fourteen lakh rupees.

Scene 11: Ramlal discloses the facts; Siyaram's fainting and Ram Kishun's denial intensify dramatic tension.

Scene 12: A complaint is brought before the sarpanch, turning a family dispute into a formal public controversy.

Scene 13: On receiving notice, Ram Kishun mobilises his political and social defences.

Scene 14: At the first panchayat, the apparent absence of evidence and Lakhan's refusal to cooperate undermine Ramlal's claim.

Scene 15: Domestic conflict, violence against Lakshmi, fighting between father and son, and the forcible taking of a mark complicate the ethical struggle.

Act Two: Scene-by-Scene Discussion

Scene 1: Fearing his son, Lakhan seeks refuge with Ram Kishun; the web of deception encloses the family once again.

Scene 2: Ramlal writes to the sub-divisional and district authorities; the struggle for rights extends into offices.

Scene 3: Official correspondence concerning the complaint passes through various offices to the police station, making the administrative chain clear.

Scene 4: The police investigate Ram Kishun's home; the search for truth falters between hospitality and pressure.

Scene 5: A discussion of money for keeping the police diary deliberately incomplete reveals the deterioration of judicial credibility.

Scene 6: The district officer insists on evidence, while Ram Kishun seeks fresh means of influence.

Scene 7: An attempt is made to deflect the investigation through influential police contacts; bribery reaches political power.

Scene 8: The district officer expresses suspicion; police warnings and unethical transactions are exposed.

Scene 9: Bir proposes the fatal removal of Ramlal, turning economic crime into violent crime.

Scene 10: Conversations involving Ramlal, Jhamlal, Lakshmi, and Bir; the tea shop prepares deception onstage.

Scene 11: Ram Kishun and Bir arrange a contract killing through the criminal leader Raja.

Scene 12: Bir takes Ramlal away; the gang murders him. This is the tragic climax of the play.

Scene 13: Ramlal's absence worries Lakshmi and Jhamlal; fear grows at home amid discussion of the police.

Scene 14: Maternal uncle Lakshman becomes active, and suspicion falls on Bir; private grief becomes a desire to investigate.

Scene 15: The family seeks help from Ram Kishun; the criminal conceals his role.

Scene 16: The remaining payment is discussed within the criminal gang; the audience receives comprehensive confirmation of the contract killing.

Act Three: Scene-by-Scene Discussion

Scene 1: The maternal uncle's initiative, debate about a police complaint, and Ram Kishun's double reaction.

Scene 2: Arrangements for a social meeting—the first form of civic organisation.

Scene 3: A panchayat in the community hall, Lakshmi's statement, and a proposal for compensation; Ram Kishun refuses public opinion.

Scene 4: Protest, applications, and demands for justice before officials; private grief becomes public politics.

Scene 5: Stern action by police and the district officer; the contradiction between anti-corruption speeches and the use of force.

Scene 6: Degrading violence in the treatment of the accused; the point at which criticism of the limits of justice is most necessary.

Scene 7: Administrative consultations and preparations for a public hearing; resolution becomes centred on a higher officer.

Scene 8: News of the elimination of the criminal gang and the imposition at the public hearing of a total ten-lakh-rupee liability upon four wrongdoers.

Scene 9: A proposal to invest in education, financial payments, public praise, Lakhan's grief, and Ram Kishun's apology reveal the limits of compensation.

06 / 06

Bhaet

Democracy, Electoral Power, and Public Theatre

The Public Stage of Democracy

In Maithili theatrical tradition, the experiences of village crossroads, verandahs, public meetings, reconciliation, folk songs, teasing, and collective disputes have continually empowered stage dialogue. Bechan Thakur's *Bhaet* places a distinctive political moment in this public life—a parliamentary election—at the centre of drama. The word *Bhaet* in the title is associated within the work with voting, the right to vote, the buying and selling of votes, and the meaning of public opinion. The work's cover identifies it as a social and political play. It is therefore appropriate to classify it as a social drama with elements of political farce; to call it a children's play would contradict the textual evidence.

The play first presents candidates' families and intimate gatherings with their advisers. It then turns public institutions into theatrical sites: the election commissioner's office, the documentary processes of nomination, campaign stages, the panchayat building, police station, polling centre, tea shop, Bhagwati temple, and district headquarters. Private ambitions gradually become institutional crises and community decisions. Rulers, officers, security personnel, brokers, political associates, a female candidate, and voters are mutually dependent in this movement. The work's importance lies not merely in teaching the selection of a 'good leader', but in its dramatic examination of how the language of public welfare can become a cover for opportunism.

The Arrangement of the Subject: Five Candidates and a Public World

The cast list contains 101 numbered roles. The five principal candidates are Gobardhanlal, Phiran, Brajesh, Subhadra, and Vivek. Gobardhanlal combines

idealistic political aspirations with financial weakness; Phiran represents previous electoral defeat and dependence on others for financial arrangements; Brajesh, as a sitting member of Parliament, embodies arrogance of office and control over resources; Subhadra supports public service, moderation, and women's political participation; and Vivek represents the display of violent power and anarchic opportunism. These characters are largely constructed as theatrical signs of particular social tendencies rather than fully individuated people, although psychological subtlety is also visible in certain passages.

The opening conversation in Gobardhanlal's home begins with banter about sweets; the possibility of standing for election immediately raises anxiety about a shortage of money. In Phiran's home, the experience of former defeats and loss of land is transformed into electoral bargaining through Rakesh's confidential financial assurances. At Brajesh's residence emerge his indifference towards reports of public hostility, his desire for personal advancement, and a deceptive financial scheme to gather supporters. At Subhadra's gathering, the emotional wound of an earlier defeat and opposition to improper expenditure appear as an inner struggle within political character. At Vivek's place, drinking and boastful reliance on muscle power sharpen the play's line of crisis.

In these five introductions, each candidate addresses a party or circle of associates, but readers hear even more about the political system itself. Gobardhanlal's inability, Phiran's ambition, Brajesh's arrogance, Subhadra's ethical conflict, and Vivek's open threats of violence together form a moral scale against which to measure the available possibilities of democracy.

Individual Close Readings of the Scene Sequence

Gobardhanlal's Verandah: Public Welfare and Electoral Capital

At the beginning, friends' banter over sweets lays the foundation of social intimacy. The moment a proposal to contest the election appears, humour gives way to financial anxiety. There is a gulf between praise for Gobardhanlal's qualifications and the reality of the money required to win an election. The possibility of selling a *bigha* of farmland suggests that entry into public representation can itself threaten financial ruin. Rameshwar's invitation to eat and Jitendra's ethical advice reveal the mixed presence of cooperation and self-interest within the same group.

Phiran's Home: A History of Defeat and Sponsored Candidacy

Phiran recounts repeated defeats in earlier elections for headman and the sale of his land. The arrival of Rakesh, a close associate of Brajesh, is thus a significant dramatic reversal. The offer of assistance uses the language of independent public service, but financial assurances draw the candidate into a powerful opponent's design. Rakesh's indirect purpose—to divide votes or influence electoral arithmetic—is inferred from the dialogue and situation; it is not presented here as a demonstrably declared objective.

Brajesh's Residence: The Character of Power Estranged from the Public

Suresh and Rakesh report dissatisfaction within the constituency. Brajesh underestimates the people's judgement and relies on plans to tempt them when the election approaches. The bodyguard's dream during sleep creates an independent comic scene that also hints at disorder and complacency within the centre of power. After electoral money passes into Rakesh's hands, his intention to keep a share for himself exposes corruption among intermediaries: the opportunity created by major corruption reproduces itself on a smaller scale.

Subhadra's Residence: The Pain of Defeat and Ethical Alternatives

Subhadra's emotional response to losing an earlier election by a very narrow margin prevents her from becoming an inert emblem of virtue. Umakant argues for the expenditure and struggle necessary to win in practice; Subhadra wishes to avoid improper means. Her political family background and unmarried life are also mentioned. A necessary critical precaution here is that granting a woman's public service moral legitimacy solely because she has renounced marriage can reproduce patriarchal judgements. Subhadra's distinctiveness should be sought in her ability to decide, her service, and her conduct during elections, not in compulsory renunciation of life's choices.

Vivek's Den: The Unrestrained Language of Violence

Vivek's group fantasises about bombs, weapons, seizing polling booths, and acquiring personal property. Corrupt political ambition travels together with humour, drinking, and vulgar songs. Such language may make an audience laugh, but it also evokes fear of the armed hijacking of democracy. These early declarations of violence become narratively connected to the later bloodshed at the polling centre.

The Election Commission: Administrative Problems and Dramatic Examination

Commissioner Rampratap and deputy Giriraj make a successive list of obstacles to voting: booth capture, tampering with ballot boxes or machines, inadequate training, access to remote areas, management of time, vote-buying, and security crises. This section functions as a policy discussion within the play. Its strength is identifying administrative failures before they become political events; its weakness is that reading out a list often becomes a lecture instead of dramatic confrontation. A quarrel among lower-level office employees finally confronts the grand speech on improving administration with practical human weakness.

The Nomination Office: Documents, Influence, and Petty Exactions

The long nomination scene tests the contrasting conduct of five parties against the same administrative apparatus. Gobardhanlal must correct a small error; Phiran is uncomfortable filling in his form and depends on the official's indulgence; Brajesh's application bears the stamp of privilege; Subhadra prepares her documents with comparative clarity; and Vivek's swagger

responds violently to demands for compliance with rules. Peon Raghav's expectation of a payment, the employees' helplessness, and unequal enforcement of formal rules constitute powerful institutional satire. 'Paper' becomes both the gateway to popular representation and a routine opportunity for corruption.

Gobardhanlal's Rally: Exaggerated Celebration of Virtues

Supporters cite Gobardhanlal's honesty, diligence, and ties with the public as qualifications for election. Their language is adulatory and full of advance declarations of victory. For readers who have seen his opening financial crisis, this theatrical praise becomes ambiguous: even when the candidate possesses genuine qualities, the management of a crowd turns them into slogans.

Phiran's Rally: Song, Manifesto, and Opportunity

The musical campaign of Phiran's party uses recurring folk melodies and the rhythm of slogans. General promises of public service, education, roads, and religious coexistence make the political voice attractive, but the financial bargain behind the scenes casts a shadow of suspicion over those promises. The distance between presentation and intention is the subject of criticism here.

Brajesh's Rally: The Economy of Gifts and Impossible Promises

The distribution of clothes and declarations of exaggerated welfare schemes make the rally absurd. The sight of people returning empty-handed because gifts have run out reveals the limits of inducements. The real responsibilities of government disappear amid a crowd of impossible promises of distributing goods. The exaggeration of these promises is a device of satire; it would be a mistake to read them as an objective list of government policies.

Subhadra's Rally: Few Words and a Demand for Accountability

Mala emphasises the judicious use of voting rights; in response to the temptation of money, Subhadra speaks of public relationships and work. Without saying so explicitly, the meeting becomes a counterpoint to the preceding three campaign episodes. Subhadra's self-presentation is comparatively restrained, yet her party's slogans are not free of the ridiculous world of party symbols. This tension between the ethical individual and the linguistic machinery of elections is one of the play's subtle achievements.

Vivek's Rally: The Public Declaration of Crime

Here the domineering candidate makes his intention to seize the vote almost an object of public comedy. Warnings from his associates do not weaken his confidence. The play exposes and makes public the normally concealed relationship between power and crime. The theatrical risk is that excessive vulgarity may sometimes lighten the political horror of violence.

Bachcha Babu's Panchayat Meeting: The Irony of the Voters' Collective Judgement

Villagers assemble in the panchayat building to assess the five parties. Their opening discussion turns to public service, candidates' conduct, and social

unity. Yet as the candidates arrive one by one and distribute money, the process of collective decision-making becomes a market. Bachcha Babu is a social intermediary, not a just public representative. The village's supposed solidarity is made and unmade through calculations of values, pressure, inducements, and shared gains. The scene does not permit the failure of democracy to be dismissed as merely the fault of leaders: voters too come under critical scrutiny.

The Police Station: Prohibitory Orders, Intoxication, and Punitive Governance

The police announce measures for election security and crowd control. The scene includes a public notice prohibiting campaigning, an episode involving intoxication, and harsh police conduct. The play juxtaposes the need for security with a tendency to humiliate citizens. The boundary between enforcing the law and unlawful arbitrariness becomes a critical question.

The Polling Centre: A Direct Confrontation Between Order and Violence

A school has become a polling centre. Identity cards, voting machines, the presiding officer, and armed security personnel are present. An attempt to capture the booth interrupts ordinary voting procedures, and several characters are killed or injured in gunfire. The full weight of the preceding discussion is concentrated in this scene: what had appeared as the possibility of wrongdoing in earlier declarations now becomes a fatal event. The staging of violence is extensive, so a school-based production with adolescents would require care and adaptation.

The Tea Shop: Rumours of Defeat and Partisan Barbs

After voting, workers from rival groups meet at a tea shop. Discussion of candidates' prospects, alliances, booth violence, and reciprocal accusations turns the shop into a temporary public assembly. The language is quarrelsome, but informal public opinion also takes shape here. Not all political dialogue is produced in public speeches; it is also made in ordinary commercial spaces. This is a perceptive recognition of folk life in the play.

The Bhagwati Temple: Religious Belief as Electoral Exchange

Candidates visit priest Devanath with hopes of victory and questions of offerings or ritual fees. The temple becomes both a site of political ritual and self-interested mediation. The language of devotion mingles with electoral calculations to generate satire. The issue for the critic is not the devaluation of religious faith but the irony of involving religious institutions in bargaining over victory.

Security of the Voting Machines: Refused Bribes and Duty

Before counting, a group of Brajesh's henchmen attempts to tamper with the securely held voting machines. Mahendra and Ravindra reject financial offers, after which there is gunfire and injury. The scene creates positive counterparts in the form of honest government employees. This perspective

matters after the earlier picture of administrative corruption: the playwright does not declare the entire system equally fallen.

The Count: Numerical Evidence and the Failure of a Proposal to Seize Power

At district headquarters, following the count and the honouring of security personnel, the results are announced. Subhadra receives 125,361 votes, Gobardhanlal 50,009, Phiran 15,080, and Brajesh 5,002; Vivek's total is not stated separately. The winner's margin over the nearest rival is 75,352 votes, as arithmetic confirms. When an influential telephone call seeks to change the result, the district magistrate's refusal becomes the play's ethical climax. Subhadra wins by a very large margin; the corrupt power visible only moments earlier thus seems ineffective before an overwhelming popular mandate.

Post-Victory Public Contact: The Open Test of the Duties of Office

The final scene does not stop at celebrations of Subhadra's victory. It ends with promises to visit the public even after being elected, tour the constituency regularly, and listen to people's problems. This produces a scene opposite to Brajesh's initial distance from his constituents. The character's future actions are not shown in the play; the promises are therefore an ethical programme, not demonstrated achievements. The final critical question is which long-term institutional measures will turn declarations into accountability.

Character Construction and the Social Meaning of 101 Roles

Giving names to 101 roles is more than expanding the crowd. From the election commission to village voters, peons, clerks, security personnel, priests, local brokers, and party workers, the cast list extends the play's social terrain. Although power is concentrated at the top, its operation depends upon intermediate institutions and the conduct of ordinary people. Brajesh's parliamentary position does not make him omnipotent; security personnel at the polling centre and the counting officer set limits on his influence.

Such abundance of characters also makes staging difficult. Most roles have a clear function, not a private life history. This has advantages for a large community production, in which many performers may participate; for a small professional company, abridgement, doubling of roles, and planning of ensemble scenes would be necessary. Reading Bechan Thakur's theatrical tradition in the context of public participation and parallel theatre reveals this work's distinctive theatrical meaning.

Power, Money, and Ethics: Three Interconnected Economies

First comes inequality of resources: Gobardhanlal's life based on landholding and Brajesh's enormous electoral means do not make equality within the same competition possible. Second is the intermediary economy of opportunism: Rakesh, local organisers, and nomination employees take shares of money circulating between politics and society. Third is the symbolic

economy of garlands, slogans, praise, food, alcohol, the distribution of clothes, religious offerings, and victory celebrations. At the intersection of these three economies, the vote risks becoming a marketable commodity rather than a civic decision.

The political heart of the play is therefore more than satire of corrupt public representatives. At the village meeting, supposed 'collective wisdom' gradually assumes the form of collective acceptance of gifts. This raises the question of whether democratic education ends with electoral registers and instruction in using voting machines, or whether it also demands collective judgement, the capacity to express dissent, and the practice of rejecting short-term gains. At this level, the text can become a popular school of institutional ethics.

The Aesthetics of Satire, Folk Humour, and the Disruption of Rasa

In most episodes, the satire lies more in the situation than in the words. An invitation to enjoy sweets collides with the financial crisis of electoral life; government officers extol rules while pressure operates inside their own offices; campaigners promise public progress while exhibiting untrustworthy indulgence; and a temple's blessings become a form of political investment. Humour here mingles with compassion, fear, and indignation.

Several scenes may be read through the Indian theatrical vocabulary of comic, furious, fearful, and heroic sentiments. This is not an inflexible classification of the work into *rasas*, but a comparison of dramatic effects. Gunfire at the polling centre breaks the continuity of humour. Vulgar episodes of crowd-pleasing folk farce also sometimes weaken powerful political criticism; in particular, insulting language and jokes about drinking can both resist authority and satisfy an audience's easy appetite for entertainment. The critic must explain rather than evade this tension.

Language, Speech, and Multilingual Characterisation

Local colloquial Maithili forms the underlying axis of the entire play. Onstage one hears administrative Hindi, Hindi-mixed dialogue among security personnel, Vivek's group's unstable Maithili-Hindi mixture, and different uses of rural proverbs. Language maps the social world: officials use bureaucratic vocabulary; politicians adopt popular forms of address and slogans; intimidating power uses the tone of vulgar threats. The aesthetic value of these differences must be sought not simply in linguistic purity or impurity, but in characters' power relationships and their roles before listeners.

The Contradictions of Women's Representation: Subhadra's Political Agency

As the only major female candidate, Subhadra carries particular weight within the play's gender structure. Her colleague Mala actively participates in policy discussion, yet independently political female characters are scarce in the other groups. Subhadra's electoral journey moves from the memory of

defeat to renewed action, resistance to improper expenditure, a succinct account of the duties of public office at rallies, victory in the count, and a renewed promise of public contact. This degree of development partly saves her from becoming a passive symbol.

Nonetheless, the verbal convention of supporting the moral superiority of her character through her father's prestige and her decision not to marry invites criticism. The justification of women's political rights should rest upon service and autonomous intellectual decisions. These foundations are clearly present in the text, yet an ideal of womanhood defined by sacrifice accompanies them. The work's strength lies in making this contradiction visible.

The Historical Perspective of Parallel Maithili Theatre

Gajendra Thakur's *A Complete Critical Appreciation of Bechan Thakur*, published in Videha, places Bechan Thakur's writings within a socially committed tradition of parallel Maithili theatre. It gives *Bhaet* particular importance because of electoral corruption, the criminalisation of power, and the political breadth created by its many roles. This external critical proposition provides a framework for examination, not automatic proof from the primary play. In the present reading, changes of setting from local verandahs to election offices, the multitude of characters, and an open examination of democratic hypocrisy support that proposition.

Ashish Anchinhar's *Bechan Thakurjik Natak Chhinar Devi* (Videha, issue 82, 2011) documents Videha's critical engagement with Thakur's plays. The works do not have identical subjects—gendered social questions are central to *Chhinar Devi*, electoral politics to *Bhaet*—yet they share the generic direction of examining social injustice on a vernacular stage. The latter work can consequently be read as part of a broader dramatic project of social concern, without introducing unread incidents from the other play merely to demonstrate similarity.

Brechtian Distancing, Popular Engagement, and the Practical Demands of Staging

The characters' direct discussion of the political system amid scenes of farce does not confine the audience to an emotional centre of pity or fear; it also gives them an opportunity to question the causes underlying that system. In this sense, Bechan Thakur's theatrical method invites critical comparison with Brechtian alienation. The text, however, offers no documentary evidence of direct historical influence, and the relationship must therefore be described as one of formal resemblance alone. Public debate involving a large cast, the sequence of campaign scenes, electoral songs, and the episodic expansion of the plot together give the play a collective rather than an individual heroic perspective.

A stage adaptation would face considerable difficulty in accommodating 101 characters, the arrangements for five campaign groups, numerous offices, festive gatherings, panchayat meetings, a temple, and successive changes of location to polling stations. A village community theatre festival could accommodate broad participation; a theatre with limited resources would benefit from symbolic sets, choral voices, distinct lighting areas, and the combining of supporting roles. If the shooting scene were conveyed through light, sound, and acting rather than the display of realistic firearms, the horror of violence could be preserved without unnecessary sensationalism.

A Comparative Reading in the History of Children's Literature: Generic Distance, Not Equivalence

Videha's research collections provide archival evidence of distinct writing on children's folklore, illustrated stories, children's novels, and children's drama. Phoolchandra Jha 'Praveen's' *Maithili Shishu Lok Sahitya* (issue 50, 2010), Dr Yoganand Jha's *Maithili Ballokkatha: Sthiti a Apeksha* (issue 76, 2011), Durganand Mandal's *Nena Lel Sundar Chitrakatha* (issue 116, 2012), and Ramesh Ranjan's *Maithili Balnatak Seema Vistar Karait—Chauari* (issue 126, 2013) are archival indications of these distinct areas of inquiry. Gajendra Thakur's *Maithili Bal-Upanyasak Samikshashastra* (issue 447, 2026) examines in detail child-centred narrative structures, folk memory, children's agency, and adaptation appropriate to young readers. On the basis of these references, it is more appropriate to examine the possibilities and limitations of *Bhaet* for young readers than to force it into the category of children's literature.

Children's folktales generally depend upon the receptive capacities of the child's mind, imagination, sonic rhythm, and a compact narrative cycle; illustrated narratives give priority to the mutual support of words and pictures; and children's theatre centres on roles appropriate to young performers, manageable duration, participation, and the ethical presentation of fear and emotional intensity. *Bhaet* contains 101 characters, extended institutional dialogue, complicated transactions between political parties, abusive political speech, drinking, and bloody violence. These features make the work, in its primary character, a political drama for adult audiences.

Nevertheless, selected scenes inspired by the work could be useful in a curricular adaptation for adolescent civic education. Transparency in nominations, secrecy of the ballot, the consequences of inducements, women's leadership, the prevention of electoral violence, and responsibility for public contact after victory are suitable subjects for discussion in senior classes. Such use would not alter the original generic identity of *Bhaet*; an adapted production for adolescents would constitute a new creative theatrical experiment.

The Text's Principal Achievements and Limitations: A Critical Balance

The first major achievement is the dramatic representation of the entire electoral life cycle, from the selection of candidates to promises made after the election. Second is the inclusion, alongside politicians, of voters, junior employees, security personnel, intermediaries, and priests, making corruption a multilayered social event. Third is the elevation of local speech and village public spaces into the intellectual centre of the play. Fourth is the preservation of possibilities for resistance through a female candidate and honest public employees. Fifth is the documentary-style ending with an actual count of votes within the fiction, followed by the elected representative's pledge to work.

The limitations are not insignificant. The breadth of 101 characters renders many roles flat. The episode concerning the Election Commission sometimes becomes more of a lecture on political ethics than a dramatic scene. Coarse abuse and jokes about alcohol can obstruct the force of social criticism. In presenting the female candidate as a moral ideal, the text does not fully free itself from the conventional image of women's self-sacrifice. The greatest problem of narrative plausibility is that, after depicting the public's widespread acceptance of inducements, the play does not sufficiently elaborate the political process that makes Subhadra's victory by an enormous margin possible. Although morally satisfying, the conclusion is somewhat hurried in its realistic chain of causes and effects.

Numerical Verification of the Election Result and Its Ideological Meaning

Verification of the margin: 125,361 − 50,009 = 75,352. The margin announced in the play agrees with this figure. This numerical consistency in the counting of votes is important; nevertheless, when interpreting the mandate, the result must be understood as part of the playwright's imagined political world, not as data from a real election.

Conclusion: The Unfinished Passage from Popular Mandate to Public Service

Bhaet is an ambitious work in the sociopolitical development of Maithili drama. Its overall structure presents democracy not merely as a moral sermon but as a public process. Moving from private conversation on the village verandah to election-office records, from the village panchayat to the risks of voting, and from religious sites to administrative decisions, the play reveals the mechanisms of power through a succession of small actions. Its collective dimension gives it breadth, but that same collectivity sometimes weakens its poetic concentration.

The final victory clearly expresses the playwright's faith that people can exercise sound judgement in the face of money, violence, and deceit. Yet victory is not conclusive proof of virtue. The real test will be Subhadra's future service to the public, which would begin only after the play ends. The work's enduring relevance lies in this open question. Its most valuable contribution, in the view of this study, is to conceive of democratic culture not as a procedure confined to ballot papers or voting machines but as a continuing practice of public accountability.

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STUDY 09 / NIT NAVAL

Kunal

Chapter 1

Kunal's Dramatic World: Folk Theatre, Classical Tradition, and Criticism

A Comprehensive Study of Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays

1. Introduction: The Collection and Its Publication History

Kunal's Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays occupies a distinctive place in contemporary Maithili dramatic literature. Both in its substantive concerns and in its formal construction, the collection is oriented towards performance. These are not merely "closet dramas," written to be read rather than performed, but plays that have been repeatedly staged, tested in performance, and refined through theatrical experiment. The publisher's account substantiates this: all seven plays were first staged at Vidyapati Bhavan in Patna and were subsequently published in periodicals such as Bhangima and Antika. A critical examination of the collection must therefore go beyond textual interpretation to place theatricality—the plays' potential and actual life onstage—at the centre of its inquiry.

The dedication page is itself a manifesto for the theatre: "To the known and unknown people and artists who perform plays ('naach') from village to village, and to J. Brahmanand, the Vishvakarma of Bhangima." This dedication contains in embryo Kunal's entire theatrical vision. On one side, he honours the anonymous village performers of naach, a tradition that has lived in the soil of Mithila for centuries while remaining largely unnamed in institutional literary histories. On the other, he acknowledges his theatre company, Bhangima, several of whose artists—including J. Brahmanand—participated in the original productions. The cover illustration is by Vinay Ambar and bears clear echoes of Mithila's tradition of folk painting.

2. The Architecture of the Collection: A Design in Two Cycles

Considered together, the seven plays fall into two readily discernible cycles. The author does not explicitly announce this division, yet it emerges from their form, their sources, and the chronology of their composition.

(a) The folk-theatre trilogy comprises Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha, Bidapat, and the title play Kusma-Salhes. All three are expansive, populous, song-and-dance-rich dramas grounded in Mithila's own narrative and performance

traditions—naach, Salhes Naach, and Bidapat Naach. Their dates of composition range from 1990 to 2006.

(b) The quartet of love consists of The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory!; The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage; The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery; and The Test of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra. These four relatively short plays, with economical casts and mythological or narrative foundations, were published in Antika in 2013–14. Their titles follow a common pattern, beginning with an abstract emotional or ethical value—love or faith. At the centre of each play stands a woman who makes decisions for herself.

What binds these two cycles is the affirmation of love as a vital principle of existence. The refrain of the closing song of Kusma-Salhes—"As a flower is without nectar, so what is life without love?"—returns almost verbatim in Shweta's Discovery. Thus a continuous thread of thought extends from the folk-theatre trilogy to the quartet of love.

3. A General Survey of the Seven Plays

3.1 Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha, or The Tale of Gyan Jha

This is the first and most formally experimental work in the collection. Its opening offers a particularly fine example of self-referential theatre. Three bhats, traditional bards, enter the stage and lament their dying art: "Our learning has now become useless." When their customary verses and songs of praise fail to move their audience, they decide that they must stage a play instead. Within this single scene Kunal dramatises three historical realities at once: the decline of Maithili bardic culture, the crisis of arts formerly sustained by royal patronage, and the transition of traditional performers towards the theatre.

Within this outer frame unfolds a familiar tale from the Gonu Jha cycle of Mithila. The ruler has bestowed upon Gonu the title of "supreme master of cunning"; humiliated court poets approach him seeking justice; and eventually a band of forty thieves sets out to plunder his house. Gonu defeats them not by force but by intelligence. He inflames their rivalry with the symbolic lure of the headcloth of leadership and deceives them through a farcical, fraudulent coronation ritual. The result is an unusual union of hasya rasa, the comic sentiment, and vira rasa, the heroic sentiment: heroism becomes an attribute of ingenuity rather than of arms.

The play reaches its intellectual climax at the end, when the bhats step out of their roles and dispute the story's conclusion: "But in that case, brother, hasn't the ending of the play changed?" Through this exchange Kunal reveals the fluidity of theatrical reality, the possibility of alternative endings, and the visibility of the creative process before an audience. This is followed by a pointed social observation: theft is described as a social malady "arising from illiteracy and poverty," to be addressed through just social arrangements rather than punishment alone.

At the close the bhats spread out a gamchha, a cotton cloth, and ask the audience for contributions. This is not simply a realistic depiction of the collection of a folk performer's fee; it is also a moving recognition of the relation between artistic labour and livelihood. The final song declares, "There is no strength greater than intelligence." This is the thesis of the drama as a whole and gives meaning to its alternative title, The Tale of Gyan Jha.

Seen from the perspective of Navya-Nyaya, the play's central value of intelligence is, more precisely, a celebration of prama (valid cognition) and yukti (reasoned method). Every one of Gonu's victories is won not through physical strength but through inference, imaginative conjecture, and argument. Beneath its comic surface, the play offers an indigenous affirmation of epistemological inquiry.

3.2 Bidapat

Bidapat—the popular pronunciation of Vidyapati's name—provides one of the most accomplished examples of Kunal's dramatic craftsmanship. The title page calls it "a play based on the techniques of folk theatre," but its form is actually a synthesis of classical and popular theatrical traditions. The work opens with purvaranga, the preliminary performance, and adopts the classical dialogue between the sutradhara and the actress, while also incorporating the samaji or chorus, the clown-like Vipata, and Natua, familiar figures of the folk stage.

Its most remarkable formal achievement lies in the dense, careful, and purposeful use of Vidyapati's own songs. Invocations to Shiva and Bhairavi, verses celebrating spring ("A new Vrindavan, ever-new groves … the youthful lover plays"), songs of separation ("Shape a face from the essence of the moon, eyes like the startled chakora"), and the concluding song in the Avahatta manner are woven into the dramatic movement so closely that the play becomes, in effect, a theatrical commentary on Vidyapati's lyrics.

The plot weaves Vidyapati's life through three strands of relationship: his patron and friend Shiv Singh, Shiv Singh's queen Lakhima, and the well-known legend of his servant Ugna, who was in fact Lord Mahadeva. The closing movement is deeply affecting: Shiv Singh disappears during the battle of Oini; Lakhima refuses to accept that her husband is dead and persists in waiting for him; and Vidyapati carries his grief throughout his life. Lakhima is not represented as a conventional image of the sati, but as a resolute, dignified woman who chooses to wait. This is a subtle rereading of the inherited narrative.

The play's power of suggestion—dhvani in the terminology of Indian poetics—reaches its height in its ending. Vidyapati declares that he will remain alive in his songs, and that Shiv Singh, Lakhima, Vipata, Natua, and Ugna will also achieve immortality through them. Beneath the karuna rasa of sorrow runs a deeper current of shanta rasa, tranquillity: poetry's enduring life is set against bereavement and death. Ultimately, Bidapat takes Vidyapati

down from the institutional literary historian's pedestal of "great poet" and restores him to life as a hero of folk theatre. It is an outstanding dramatic instance of Videha's approach to parallel history.

3.3 Kusma-Salhes

That this is the title play is no accident of its centrality: artistically and ideologically, it is the heart of the collection. Its title page describes it as a "play based on the epic legend of Raja Salhes and the folk theatre of Salhes Naach." Raja Salhes is the folk-deity and hero of Mithila's Dusadh (Dalit) community, while Salhes Naach is the performance tradition associated with him. The choice of source is itself a cultural and political statement. Rather than draw on Mithila's elite-centred literary inheritance, Kunal bases his most ambitious drama on a subaltern epic.

The cast expands on an epic scale: Salhes, king of Mahisautha; Kusma, the gardener heroine; Hiraman, the parrot who carries the narrative; Vipata, the clown of naach; Salhes's animal companions, the tiger Thanka and the bear Banka; the yogini sisters of the gardener community; kingdoms such as Morang, Bhot, Baghgarh, and Samdagarh; and the goddess Durga herself. This breadth preserves the defining structure of Salhes Naach: the preliminary ritual, invocation or sumiran, choral singing, and a geographical journey unfolding scene by scene.

The opening sumiran is a remarkable statement of religious and cultural syncretism. Alongside gods, Baba-Dihbar, gurus and gosains, the rising sun, the Ganges, and Gora-Parvati, it invokes Mira-Sultan, a Muslim pir associated with the west, and finally "all society" and "the people of the nation." Even the greetings addressed to the spectators are inclusive: "Pranam, namaste, adaab, good evening, salaam." Such syncretism belongs to the cultural character of the Dusadh Salhes tradition itself, which Kunal brings to the stage with fidelity.

Kusma's account of herself—born a princess, she abandoned the palace to become a forest-dwelling gardener—is rich in the imagery and resonances of folk poetry. Memories of pilgrimages to Janakpur, Kamru-Kamakhya, and Visunpur, together with the words spoken by Durga in a dream when Kusma was twelve, supply its emotional landscape. Yet the play's central conflict is not simply a romance; it is the struggle between love and the hunger for power.

That conflict culminates when the expansionist emperor Suchong chains Salhes in the prison at Rangilagarh and dreams of exercising undisputed sovereignty over all Mithila. The soul of the drama speaks through Salhes's response: "My life may be in your fist, Emperor. But my thoughts and feelings cannot be bound. Salhes may cease to exist, but the people, filled with the message of a life free from fear, will remain." In this single speech, Kunal transforms the Dusadh folk-deity Salhes into a people's hero, a symbol of fearlessness and freedom; the gardener sisters become embodiments of peace, compassion, affection, joy, and the welfare of the people.

The play closes with collective song and dance, giving voice to its enduring refrain: "Love is truth, love is fragrance, the feeling of love is everlasting; as a flower without nectar, so what is life without love?" Here the erotic sentiment, shringara rasa, transcends its worldly plane to become a universal human principle. Love is not merely attachment between individuals, but a creative force in existence. With the authenticity of its folkloric sources, its political awareness, and its poetic consummation brought together, this is the strongest play in the collection.

3.4 The Quartet of Love: Four Heroines from Myth

The final four plays form a coherent sequence of ideas. All share a common dramatic grammar: a limited cast, doubling of roles by the same actor, tiered or bare staging, a narrator or announcer, and intermittent use of Vidyapati's songs. Through their four mythological or narrative heroines they affirm modern values: women's agency, self-determination, and the dignity of love.

The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory! Shruvavati, daughter of the sage Bharadvaja, rejects the conventional criteria of marriage—a handsome, wealthy, and valiant husband—and declares that she will marry only when someone becomes genuinely "meaningful" to her. Calling herself an "independent and self-reliant" person, she wishes to be an "exception" to tradition. Indra, disguised as Vashishtha, challenges her to cook a fruit before sunset. The fruit turns to stone; but Shruvavati, finding a life bereft of the memory of love meaningless, resolves to enter the funeral pyre. Her strength of will compels Indra to yield. The play's central proposition is that "inner strength is a human being's greatest wealth." Although the convention of entering the fire creates tension with the feminist reading of the work, its focus is on the force of resolve rather than on sacrifice.

The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage. This dramatisation of the Sukanya–Chyavana episode from the Mahabharata concerns the lively, playful princess Sukanya and the aged sage Chyavana, absorbed in meditation within an anthill. It begins with Vidyapati's spring song, "The king of seasons, spring, has arrived." Amid the queen's anxiety and King Sharyati's delighted paternal affection, a subtle philosophical exchange takes place: "If you close your eyes, you will not see that tree … but everything is still there." The exchange brings the distinction between knowledge and its object onto the stage: something's not being apprehended does not imply that it does not exist. The heart of the play is faith. Sukanya's steadfastness restores Chyavana's youth.

The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery. This is the most imaginatively original work in the quartet. After seven years of rigorous artistic discipline, the court dancer Shweta falls in love with King Atiratha. Yet Atiratha remains "detached" from art: advocating the discriminating faculty of separating milk from water, he distinguishes art from the body and declares that "to fall in love would be utter folly." Shweta answers with a poet's words: "As a flower is without nectar, so what is life without love?"—the very principle heard in the closing refrain of Kusma-Salhes. She vows to compel the

"detached" king to make a declaration of love himself. The doubleness of the word "discovery" is apt: Shweta discovers both love and her own capacity to act. Kunal turns the dancer, conventionally treated as an "object," into an agent. This is the play's major achievement.

The Test of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra. The central theme of this story of the profound affection between the sage Ashtavakra—literally, "bent in eight places"—and Suprabha, daughter of the sage Vadanya, is that of testing. Vadanya sends Ashtavakra to heaven and into Urvashi's company to test Suprabha's fidelity. Suprabha refuses the prospect of choosing another king as her husband and insists that she will "wait for Ashtavakra." Ashtavakra rejects Urvashi, returns, and marries Suprabha. The closing couplet states the play's essence: "As fire makes gold shine more brightly, so love, when tested, grows more profound."

4. Kunal's Dramaturgy: Folk Theatre, Classical Tradition, and Modernity

The most striking characteristic of Kunal's theatrical language is its deliberate synthesis of three traditions. From classical Sanskrit drama he adopts the purvaranga, the dialogue of the sutradhara and actress, and an invocation resembling the nandi. From Mithila's folk theatre, or naach, he places at the centre the samaji chorus, the clown Vipata, the parrot as narrator, collective song and dance, direct address to the audience, and bare or tiered stage arrangements. The third component consists of the self-referential techniques and forms of "distancing" associated with modern theatre.

It is appropriate here to recall Western dramatic theory. Brecht's "epic theatre" and its alienation or distancing effect, through which the audience is repeatedly reminded that it is watching a play, appear in Kunal's work as organic features of folk performance. The bhat framework in Forty Thieves, the performers' abandonment of their roles and debate over alternative endings; Vipata's repeated interruption in Bidapat—"Move the story along!"; and the metatheatrical commentary of Hiraman and Vipata in Kusma-Salhes all continually break the "fourth wall." What is significant is that techniques presented by Brecht as avant-garde experiments in the West had long been intrinsic to Mithila's naach. Kunal reveals this indigenous modernity.

Kunal's attention to the practical demands of staging is exceptional. At the end of Forty Thieves he notes that the play exists in versions of forty-five minutes, sixty minutes, and one hour, and that a fourth, radio-drama version was broadcast as a series of thirteen episodes. He also proposes that a single actor may play several parts. Such details show that the texts were written with the actual needs of performance in mind: they are scripts capable of being acted, not simply imaginings of a theatrical possibility.

5. Language, Metre, and Poetic Beauty: Rasa, Dhvani, and Vakrokti

Kunal's language is not uniform but layered. In the folk-theatre trilogy he employs idiomatic rural Maithili, alliterative rhymes, and song forms in which the popular expressions of hasya, the comic, and shringara, the erotic, predominate. In the quartet of love he turns instead to a comparatively Sanskritic, tatsama-rich and literary Maithili appropriate to the atmosphere of the hermitage and the dignity of myth. These linguistic choices reveal his understanding of character and dramatic milieu.

From the perspective of vakrokti, or oblique expression, the folk plays bring verbal indirection to an intense pitch. The "headcloth of leadership," Kusma's lahathi bangles (in contrast to chains), "the wedding blessing versus the funeral rite," and the title "supreme master of cunning" all draw dramatic energy from double meanings and wordplay. From the perspective of dhvani, the ending of Bidapat (survival through song) and the refrain celebrating love in Kusma-Salhes rise beyond literal meaning towards suggestion: tranquillity sounds beneath sorrow, and a spiritual resonance arises above erotic love.

Kunal's recourse to Vidyapati's songs is a conscious poetic strategy. They are not mere ornaments; through them he seeks to make Mithila's poetic memory a living element of the stage. In Bidapat he creates a theatrical exegesis of Vidyapati's lyrics, whereas in Sukanya a spring song becomes an instrument of atmosphere. The lyric tradition and the dramatic tradition thus merge into each other.

6. A Navya-Nyaya Perspective: Valid Cognition, Absence, and Epistemic Authority

The collection contains several dramatised strands of epistemological reflection that may be interpreted through the categories of Navya-Nyaya. In Forty Thieves, each of Gonu's triumphs is a victory of inference and reasoning, and thus of valid cognition or prama. In the conflict between force and intelligence, the play elevates the processes of obtaining knowledge above the exercise of power.

The exchange in Sukanya—"If you close your eyes, you will not see the tree, but everything is still there"—brings to the stage a central Navya-Nyaya insight: the absence of knowledge of something is not the absence of the thing itself (non-apprehension is not non-existence). Without contact between the sense organ and its object, there can be no perception; nevertheless, the object remains. The distinction between knowing and what is known becomes an ethical argument for acknowledging reality.

Shruvavati's arguments about "meaningfulness" and Atiratha's faculty of discrimination between "milk and water" both raise questions concerning relations and the apprehension of qualifying properties: which quality is meaningful or acceptable within which relation? In this sense Kunal's plays also carry an indigenous epistemology beneath the appearance of entertainment.

At a broader level, the collection poses a question about epistemic authority: the validity of popular knowledge and popular memory. The Salhes epic, the Gonu cycle, and Bidapat Naach are not "unauthentic" folk narratives, but evidence of a parallel tradition of knowledge. This is the collection's unspoken proposition.

7. Ideological Foundations: The Perspective of Videha's Parallel History

The significance of this collection becomes especially apparent when viewed through Videha's conception of a parallel literary history. Institutional literary histories have tended to privilege elite-centred, printed, and supposedly "refined" traditions. Kunal instead grounds his entire dramatic practice in folk theatre and popular narrative. By dedicating his work to nameless naach performers, he brings into the centre of literary history people whose names have never been recorded there.

His presentation of the Dusadh (Dalit) folk-deity Salhes as a people's hero and a symbol of freedom and fearlessness is this perspective's most powerful expression: it is the theatrical recognition of a subaltern voice. In Bidapat, Kunal releases the great poet Vidyapati from his institutional monument and brings him alive on the folk stage. In the quartet of love, he reinterprets mythological heroines—Shruvavati, Sukanya, Shweta, and Suprabha—as women who determine their own actions. These are different aspects of the same vision of parallel history.

Resistance operates simultaneously at three levels: caste (Dalit and subaltern assertion), gender (women's agency), and culture (Hindu–Muslim accommodation). Yet it never assumes the character of slogan-making; it enters the natural movement of folk form. This is evidence of Kunal's ideological maturity.

8. Limitations and Questions

The Limitations, Weaknesses, and Ideological Tensions of the Seven Plays

Introduction: Why Criticism Is Necessary

A balanced literary assessment cannot be accomplished through praise alone. Kunal's Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays is an important contribution to Maithili dramatic literature, as demonstrated by the repeated staging of the seven plays, their publication in Bhangima and Antika, and their eventual appearance as a collected volume. Precisely this seriousness of purpose makes the reader and critic responsible: the more considerable a play's achievements, the more candidly its limitations should be acknowledged.

The purpose of identifying weaknesses, ideological tensions, formal constraints, and excessive repetitions in all seven plays is not to invalidate them, but to offer a constructive perspective for future dramatic writing.

Structural Limitations: Unequal Scale and Disrupted Rhythm

The most immediately visible structural problem of the collection is the unequal length of its seven plays. Kusma-Salhes is an expansive work of approximately seventy pages, while The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory! concludes in only fourteen. A reader or prospective director moving from Kusma-Salhes to Shruvavati is abruptly taken from an "epic world" into a short "chamber piece." The transition is not an easy one.

Consider the comparison:

Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha: 74 pages · Bidapat: 48 pages · Kusma-Salhes: 70 pages · Shruvavati: 14 pages · Sukanya: 26 pages · Shweta: 18 pages · Suprabha–Ashtavakra: 28 pages.

The average length of the first three plays is sixty-four pages, whereas that of the last four is twenty-one. This raises an issue of book architecture. The two groups seem almost to belong in different collections; their presentation within the same volume makes the reading experience feel somewhat uneven.

The Monotony of the "Or" Title Formula

The titles of all four plays in the love quartet follow the same formula: "[abstract feeling], or [heroine's name] and [an action]." In the first few instances, the pattern appears fresh, combining a classical emotion with a popular exclamation. By the fourth, however, repetition produces a mechanical effect. The reader recognises the formula as soon as the title is encountered, and the element of surprise disappears.

Compare Bidapat, one word dense with possible meanings, and Kusma-Salhes, two names suggesting epic scope. Both titles possess the vitality of their plays. The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery, by contrast, has a relatively conventional and formulaic title. This repeated titling is one of the quartet's limitations.

Weaknesses and Ideological Tensions in Individual Plays

Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha

(a) An Excess of Metatheatre

The play's metatheatrical devices—the exchanges among the bhats, the alternative endings, and direct address to the audience—are admirable from a dramaturgical standpoint. Yet when the bhats announce in the final scene that "theft is a social malady arising from illiteracy and poverty," the dramatic message becomes an act of telling. Judged by the principle attributed here to Bharata—that drama shows rather than tells—this final scene is weaker. The implied social meaning ought to emerge through what takes place on stage; the bhats' explicit interpretation is unnecessary.

(b) The Two-Dimensional Portrayal of the Thieves

Compared with Gonu Jha, the forty thieves—especially Durmatiya and Debaha—remain little more than instruments of comedy. The "social malady" of poverty and illiteracy, acknowledged by the playwright himself at the close, is given no dramatic depth in their portrayal. There is a

contradiction here: the play concludes with a progressive social explanation, yet throughout it the thieves remain objects at which the audience is invited to laugh. A social-realist dramaturgy would address this contradiction by making the thieves' deprivation humanly palpable in at least one scene.

(c) The Ambivalence of the Gamchha Episode

The scene in which the performers spread out a gamchha to collect donations works in two registers at once: as a Brechtian "transparency" that exposes the economic vulnerability of artists, and as a criticism of the patronage of the arts by the state. Yet the playwright develops neither meaning fully. The episode consequently resembles a mechanical repetition of a folk convention rather than a fully considered dramatic decision.

Bidapat

(a) Vipata's "Move the Story Along!": From Humour to Interruption

Vipata's cry, "Move the story along!", initially appears as a lively device of folk theatre. But it is repeated so often that it ceases to operate as a Brechtian distancing effect and becomes a mechanical interruption. Once spectators know that Vipata will say the same thing again, the element of surprise is lost. The alienation effect works best when it is unexpected; here it becomes entirely predictable.

(b) The Incomplete Treatment of Ugna as Mahadeva

The fact that Ugna is in truth Mahadeva is a major element of the popular legend and ought to produce one of the play's central emotional moments. Instead, Ugna's divine identity is conveyed through another character's report, in Amiyakar's words, rather than being manifested in direct dramatic action. Consequently, the episode does not achieve its full emotional force, although it represents a moment of revelation in the devotional tradition surrounding Vidyapati.

(c) The Conflict Between Historicity and Poetic Representation

The play declares its historical setting to be approximately 1400–1450 CE, yet its dramaturgy consistently adopts a poetic, folkloric register. The tension between these modes surfaces at times. The scene at the Jaunpur court, for example, invokes historical reality, but its presentation through Amiyakar's humorous impersonation diminishes that gravity. The balance between history and poetry is not always steady.

Kusma-Salhes

(a) The One-Dimensional Villains: Suchong and Chuhar

The antagonists in the collection's most ambitious play become one-dimensional figures. Suchong, Chuharmall, and Tarumall are little more than aggregates of evil attributes, without inner conflict or recognisable human complexity. When they torture Budhesar, their collective laughter ("Ho … ho …") accompanies a superficial depiction of cruelty. A compelling villain in

an epic drama ought to be capable of making spectators understand, even momentarily, his own view of the world. That complexity is absent here.

(b) Geographical Expansion at the Expense of Dramatic Focus

The action moves through an unusually large number of places: Mahisautha, Morang, Bhot, Baghgarh, Samdagarh, Rewa-Dah, and Rangilagarh. This geographic range conveys the authenticity and scale of the epic legend; dramatically, however, it frequently pushes the central story of Kusma and Salhes's love into the background. The war involving the king of Morang and the account of Bhot's invasion keep Kusma away from the stage for extended stretches. The balance between epic breadth and dramatic concentration is therefore not fully achieved.

(c) Syncretic Invocation and Cultural Disjunction

The invocation of Mira-Sultan at the beginning of the play expresses a beautiful syncretic sentiment. Yet elements specific to the Dusadh Salhes tradition—the forest goddess, animal companions, and distinctive vocabulary of Dusadh folklore—sit somewhat uneasily beside the reference to "Jana Gana Mana" in the same sumiran. Syncretism is a valuable aim, but here its enlargement makes the invocation seem less an expression of a particular Dusadh religious tradition than a display of harmony among all faiths.

The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory!

(a) Entering the Fire: A Structural Tension in the Feminist Reading

The play's most serious ideological tension arises from Shruvavati's conflicting positions. She declares herself an "independent and self-reliant person," yet when the fruit cannot be cooked she resolves to "enter the fire while remembering her beloved." The drama presents this resolve as an expression of inner strength, but the symbolic act of self-sacrifice belongs to a patriarchal convention. An autonomous woman demands life, not death. The play does not resolve this ideological contradiction.

Compare Sukanya, in the fifth play, who accepts responsibility for the consequences of her father's curse and chooses the path of life, or Ashtavakra, in the seventh, who rejects Urvashi and chooses living love. Beside these examples, Shruvavati's resolve to enter the pyre offers a weaker dramatic solution.

(b) Indra's Three Disguises: Repetition and the Loss of Credibility

Indra appears first openly, identifying himself; then in the guise of an old man; and finally as Vashishtha. These three appearances, built around Shruvavati's repeated refusals, create a dramatic rhythm that soon becomes overly predictable. The third scene of disguise, as Vashishtha, essentially repeats the second, as the old man. Shruvavati refuses both times, and Indra is angered both times. The repetition reduces rather than intensifies dramatic tension.

(c) Dushyant Kumar's Urdu Couplet: The Problem of an Imported Element

The concluding Hindi–Urdu couplet by Dushyant Kumar—"Who says the sky cannot be pierced?"—is an expression of cultural and linguistic richness. Yet it also seems somewhat out of place in this Maithili mythological one-act play. If a poetic quotation was needed, an appropriate verse might have been drawn from the Maithili poetic tradition itself. This is a minor but specific question of dramatic craft.

The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage

(a) The Age Difference and Ethical Discomfort

The drama itself acknowledges the difficulty through the chorus's song: "A sixteen-year-old daughter with flowing hair; Chyavana is a thousand years of age." The song presents the moral unease caused by this age difference in a comic manner, but the play never resolves it. Chyavana remains confident of his age and powers; the king agrees under compulsion; and Sukanya gives her willing consent. Yet the ethical basis of that consent does not receive sufficient dramatic development.

(b) The Excessive Length of the Ashvini Kumar Sequence

The first entrance of the Ashvini Kumar, their subsequent reappearance, the apology, the comparison with Urvashi, the threat of a curse, another meeting, and the episode involving soma occupy a substantial portion of the play. The principal romance—the development of Sukanya and Chyavana's relationship—receives comparatively less attention than this comic sequence. In terms of dramatic economy, removing one Ashvini episode and giving greater space to the central couple would have produced a more balanced work.

(c) The "Chyavanprash" Remark: The Danger of Temporal Rupture

The sutradhara's reference to "the Chyavana of Chyavanprash" is momentarily amusing. But this allusion to modern consumer culture creates a temporal rupture in the mythological setting. If the intention was deliberately Brechtian—a distancing effect—it ought to have been integrated into the play's dramatic purpose more consistently.

The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery

(a) Atiratha's Transformation: A Problem of Dramatic Motivation

The most serious formal weakness of this drama is the extraordinary speed of Atiratha's psychological transformation. On the one hand, the playwright depicts him as detached for "seven or eight years," a king who returns alone from every ceremony of choosing a bride. On the other, the moment he hears of Shweta's water burial, he rushes towards the riverbank and, on meeting her in the forest, removes his crown. Years of detachment dissolve in a single scene. The play supplies insufficient psychological groundwork for this transformation.

"Atiratha lost his enthusiasm"; "everything seemed artificial"; "everyone seemed like a lifeless puppet": these statements by the announcer tell us the grounds of the king's change instead of showing the change through action.

In Ibsen's Hedda Gabler or Chekhov's Three Sisters, transformations in a character's psyche emerge gradually, scene by scene. In Shweta's Discovery, Atiratha's journey depends excessively on the announcer's account and too little on direct dramatic action.

(b) The Absence of a Source Narrative

The story of Shweta and Atiratha has no identified mythological or historical source; it is an invention of Kunal's own. This originality is itself a virtue, but it produces a related weakness. The weight and credibility that a familiar mythological source lends the other six plays are absent here. The story of a "court dancer" and a "detached king" also belongs to a popular dramatic trope that has appeared in other Indian-language traditions.

The Test of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra

(a) Vadanya's Motivation: An Unexplained Rejection

The play never makes clear why the sage Vadanya rejects Ashtavakra. He declares, "I am under no obligation to explain." The dramatist employs this "mystery" as a device, but it leaves Vadanya psychologically hollow. Without knowing the reason for his refusal, spectators cannot fully understand what is at stake in the test. Vadanya becomes a functional agent of the plot rather than a living character.

(b) Suprabha's Unequal Dramatic Presence

Suprabha's name precedes Ashtavakra's in the title, Suprabha and Ashtavakra, but the first half of the play is devoted to Ashtavakra. Suprabha appears on stage only in the tenth and eleventh scenes of a twelve-scene drama, and is absent from the twelfth, the Urvashi episode. If the title gives precedence to Suprabha, the dramatic structure does not reflect that priority.

(c) The Mystery of Vandi: A Missed Dramatic Opportunity

The revelation that Vandi is actually the son of Varuna and that the supposed "water burial" involved keeping learned men in the care of the water deity for a sacrificial rite is the play's most unexpected plot twist. Yet the dramatist resolves the mystery in a humorous exchange—"Water is my very home." Had this moment been developed as a theatrical revelation, it might have become one of the play's finest scenes.

Limitations Shared Across the Collection

Women's Agency and the Sequence of Patriarchal Approval

All four plays in the love quartet share a structural characteristic that is also a limitation: each heroine's independent decision ultimately requires the approval of a male authority.

Shruvavati's victory is confirmed by Indra's declaration, "You have won"; Sukanya's marriage by the consent of King Sharyati and Chyavana; Shweta's liberation by Atiratha's decision to follow her in flight; and Suprabha's marriage by Vadanya's permission. These examples show that Kunal makes his heroines active agents, yet the final confirmation of their dramatic triumph

issues from a male character. This subtle reproduction of patriarchal authority somewhat qualifies his feminist vision.

Dependence on the Announcer: "Telling" versus "Showing"

In all four plays of the love quartet, the announcer or narrator acts as an interpreter of the characters' emotions:

"Shweta's despondency vanished …"; "Atiratha grew disheartened …"; "The night passed as though an age had passed …"

At times, such descriptions deprive the characters of the opportunity to express their emotions through their own actions. The most effective emotional moments in theatre arise when a character lives through an experience instead of having that experience narrated. Dependence on the announcer is thus a recurrent formal limitation.

The Ideological Contradiction of Divine Intervention

Several plays in the collection make emphatic assertions of female agency, yet a god or supernatural power eventually intervenes in the dramatic action.

Shruvavati's "inner strength" is validated by Indra's acknowledgement; Sukanya's "faith" is rewarded through the Ashvini Kumar's medicinal knowledge, which restores Chyavana's youth; and Ashtavakra's paternal curse is removed through bathing in a river. This pattern of divine rewards conveys an unintended message: constancy in love is necessarily rewarded by divine favour. Human agency therefore appears dependent upon providence rather than fully autonomous.

Vidyapati's Songs: The Risk of Overuse

Vidyapati's songs are employed in both Bidapat and Sukanya. In Bidapat their use is wholly appropriate and organically necessary, since Vidyapati himself is the protagonist. In Sukanya, however, the spring song "The king of seasons, spring, has arrived" serves only to create an atmosphere. This invites a question: is the collection undertaking a project of preserving Vidyapati's songs? The particular character of their use in Bidapat might have stood out more sharply if Sukanya's spring scene had drawn on a different work from the Maithili lyric tradition.

Stage Directions: Unequal Degrees of Detail

In the folk-theatre trilogy, stage directions are elaborate and particular, as in the direction describing Kusma, Thanka and Banka and the affectionate attention paid to Budhesar. In the quartet of love, by contrast, they are often minimal: "Lighting changes," "Music," "Freeze." The difference reveals the two distinct periods of Kunal's dramatic method, but it also leaves the actors in the shorter plays with less guidance.

Conclusion: Possibilities Within the Limitations

First, the quartet of love sometimes substitutes an explicit message or moral instruction for dramatic tension. Particularly in the closing couplets and the announcer's commentary, meaning is occasionally stated outright where

suggestion would have been more powerful. The essence of drama lies in showing rather than merely declaring; by this measure the folk-theatre trilogy is more assured than the quartet. Second, Shruvavati's Victory! creates ideological tension by combining a strong assertion of women's freedom with the conventional act of entering the fire. Although the play attempts to present the act as a demonstration of inner strength, a symbol centred on sacrifice cannot be wholly reconciled with its modern feminist reading. The question remains open. Third, the collection's plays are unequal in scale. An epic drama such as Kusma-Salhes and the chamber plays of the love quartet are brought together in one volume. Their diversity is a source of richness, but it also disrupts the rhythm of reading. Nevertheless, these shortcomings remain secondary when set beside the central strengths of Kunal's dramatic vision: performability and communication through popular theatrical forms.

The collection's limitations fall principally into three categories:

(a) Formal limitations: dependence on the announcer, telling rather than showing, and the one-dimensional portrayal of certain characters.

(b) Ideological tensions: the convention of entering the fire, the sequence of patriarchal approval, and dependence on divine reward.

(c) Structural limitations: unequal lengths, monotonous titles, and repeated dramatic patterns.

What matters is that these limitations do not negate the collection's value. No body of creative work is entirely free of flaws. Even the lyrics of the great poet Vidyapati repeat inherited patterns of the heroine, and the plays of Bhikhari Thakur contain linguistic unevenness. Kunal's limitations often appear precisely where his ambition reaches furthest; they are signs of a living, venturesome artist.

There is also a practical reason for identifying them: future directors can address such problems in the course of performance. A perceptive director could elaborate Atiratha's transformation through silent scenes, restage Shruvavati's resolve to enter the pyre as a proclamation of strength, or turn the revelation of Vandi's identity into an expansive theatrical moment. This is the nature of a living theatre: every production is a new version.

Concluding Assessment

Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays is a significant contribution to contemporary Maithili theatre. It forms a bridge between folk theatre and the modern stage, not merely preserving Mithila's naach tradition but reviving it through contemporary ideas. The collection rests on four pillars: intelligence in Forty Thieves; the immortality of poetry in Bidapat; freedom from fear, liberty, and love in Kusma-Salhes; and women's agency in the quartet of love. Ultimately these pillars point towards a single proposition: love, understood as universal human compassion and commitment to life, is the fundamental principle of creation, and intelligence is its protector.

Fidelity to folk sources, sensitivity towards subaltern and female voices, the synthesis of classical learning, folk forms, and modernity, and practical theatrical awareness make this collection a valuable example of Videha's parallel literary perspective and an essential point of reference for Maithili theatre criticism. Its study, teaching, and renewed staging are equally necessary to sustain the vitality of Maithili theatre.

Chapter 2

Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha, or The Tale of Gyan Jha

The Livelihood of Folk Performers, the Power of Knowledge, and Theatrical Self-Consciousness

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1. Introduction and Narrative Structure

Kunal's first play, Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha, or The Tale of Gyan Jha, occupies an unusual position in the history of Maithili drama. Its importance lies less in the subject of its story than in the manner of its telling. The play begins with a metatheatrical device: three bhats, traditional bards and singers of praise, enter the stage and lament the apparent uselessness of their art before the spectators. When they realise that their conventional recitation of poems has no effect, they propose: "What if we put on a play?" Thus a second story begins, comprising the story of the bhats as an outer frame and that of Mithila's familiar folk logician, Gonu Jha, within it.

The inner story contains several major episodes: an opening test concerning a child, in which a ploughman cleverly proves who the child belongs to; the humiliation of intelligence at the court of the subedar Bhunbhunadev; the court poets' appeal to Gonu; a journey in pursuit of justice to the fort of Ghuskiyahi; an internal struggle for power among the thieves, with Durmatiya confronting Debaha; Gonu's dream of the goddess Kali; and the ultimate defeat of the thieves through an ingenious mock coronation. A particular note by the playwright deserves attention: the play can be performed by a single actor in multiple roles; it exists in three timed versions of 45, 60, and 90 minutes; and it also became a thirteen-part radio-drama series.

The play's underlying questions are these: Who will sustain art—the state, society, or the artist? And is intelligence, or knowledge, the ultimate and supreme force in the struggle of life? These questions remain at the centre of this study across four traditions of theatrical criticism.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 The Natyashastra: The Production of Rasa and Character Types

Bharata's Natyashastra, conventionally dated here to a period extending from approximately the second century BCE to the second century CE, treats rasa as the life of drama: "Rasa is the life of theatre." The dominant rasa of this play is hasya, comedy, but it is not alone. Bharata distinguishes six varieties of laughter; of these, parastha hasya, laughter directed at others, is central here. The portrayals of the foolishness of Budhiraj, Bhunbhunadev, Durmatiya, and the band of thieves belong to this category. Atmastha hasya, laughter directed at oneself, is present as well, particularly in the bhats' self-mockery.

The determinants or alambana vibhavas of comedy are the incongruous behaviour of Bhunbhunadev and Budhiraj—"Your Majesty, I call you 'Budhiraj' because I like the name better"—the obstinacy of Durmatiya, and the helplessly comic conduct of Ranubhanu. The erotic sentiment of the Kamasutra tradition associated with Vatsyayana is absent: this is essentially a comedy. Yet there is also an extraordinary variation of vira rasa, the heroic sentiment. Gonu's courage comes from reasoning, not armed strength. Bharata describes the dhira-lalita hero as composed, witty, and intelligent; these are precisely Gonu's defining traits.

The tradition of the vidushaka. The vidushaka is a distinctive type of character in Bharata's Natyashastra: frequently a Brahmin, comically dressed but intelligent and a companion to the hero. Gonu Jha is in part an inheritor of this tradition, but Kunal redefines the figure through folk realism. Gonu is not merely a courtly clown; he is a people's logician, rooted in the soil.

2.2 Prahasana, Bhana, and the Form of Popular Performance

The prahasana, the comic dramatic genre of classical Sanskrit theatre, whether in one act or several, offers the nearest classical counterpart to this work. Bharata describes farce as combining three kinds of comic expression—mental, verbal, and physical. All three are present in Kunal's play: the bhats' verbal wit, the thieves' incongruous physical actions, and the mental comedy of Gonu's encounter with Kali.

The distinction in the Natyashastra between lokadharmi, the representation of popular or everyday conduct, and natyadharmi, conventionally stylised theatrical acting, places this drama firmly in the lokadharmi tradition. Direct address to spectators, songs, dream sequences, and ironic names—Bhunbhunadev, Budhiraj, Durmatiya—are elements of popular dramaturgy. They differ from a strictly classical mode without being any less legitimate or traditional.

2.3 Dhvani and Vakrokti

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka, composed in the ninth century, develops the theory of dhvani, the suggested meaning of language, and privileges it over literal signification and secondary indication. That principle operates at multiple levels in this play.

Literally, the alternative title The Tale of Gyan Jha denotes the story of a person. By suggestion, however, it becomes the story of knowledge or

intelligence itself. The closing song makes that meaning explicit: "There is no strength greater than intelligence." The whole intention of the play is gathered into the resonance of this phrase.

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita, from the tenth century, develops the principle of oblique expression: the striking and pleasurable rendering of a subject through unusual language. Examples abound here. The entire character of Bhunbhunadev constitutes an instance of obliqueness in naming. Consider Gonu's speech to the goddess Kali:

"O Mother! When you catch a cold … all your hands are occupied with weapons. How do you wipe the mucus from your nose?"

This remark brings faith together with laughter, devotion with intelligence, and the divine with the human in a remarkable play of indirection. It is an excellent example of vakrokti. Fear never enters the exchange: this is an oblique expression of fearlessness.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Aristotle: Mimesis, Reversal, and Catharsis

The Greek philosopher Aristotle (384–322 BCE), in his Poetics, identifies mimesis, or imitation, as central to drama, and assigns particular importance to peripeteia (reversal of circumstances) and anagnorisis (recognition) in successful tragedy. In one respect Kunal's play challenges the Aristotelian model: it is not a single-stranded tragedy but an episodic comic farce with multiple lines of action. Aristotle regarded an episodic plot as defective, whereas in the folk tradition such episodic movement can be a source of vitality.

Nevertheless, Aristotelian catharsis, the release or purification of suppressed emotion, appears here in comic form. Theft, poverty, and corruption in government are three sources of social anxiety, and the comic catharsis effected against them can be understood at a social and psychological level through Aristotle's theory.

The play also offers an inverted recognition scene. Gonu, half asleep, first "recognises" the thieves as the goddess Kali—"Mother Kali has come disguised as a man!"—and then fails to recognise them for what they are. This is a reversed anagnorisis, a comic manipulation of recognition through which laughter takes the place of fear.

3.2 Brecht: Epic Theatre and the Alienation Effect

The German dramatist and thinker Bertolt Brecht (1898–1956) theorised epic theatre and its Verfremdungseffekt, the alienation or distancing effect. Through it, performers repeatedly remind spectators that what they are seeing is a constructed theatrical event rather than reality itself, allowing critical intelligence to remain alert. Kunal's play constitutes an indigenous variation of such a Brechtian effect.

The decision of the three bhats to "put on a play" initiates the process of distancing. Throughout the performance they never become completely absorbed in the fictional world, but remain conscious of their existence as performers. At the end they return to debate alternative endings and offer the audience a social interpretation of theft as "a social malady arising from illiteracy and poverty." The passage can be viewed through Brecht's concept of Gestus, a socially revealing attitude or demonstrative action: the actor shows (zeigen) rather than simply experiences.

Brecht also drew attention to the economic conditions of art. The gamchha episode, in which the bhats openly ask the audience for money so that they can eat, embodies this kind of transparency. Brecht argued that the conditions of artistic production should not be concealed. Here they are made visible.

3.3 Lionel Abel: Metatheatre

The American critic Lionel Abel, in his book Metatheatre (1963), defined a mode of drama in which characters know themselves to be inside a play. On this definition, Forty Thieves is a complete example of metatheatre: the three bhats decide to enact a drama, select the story, and at the close expose the processes of its construction. Abel treats life as dream and theatre as awakening. Here the relationship is almost reversed: the bhats' struggle to survive is "real" and Gonu's story is a theatrical "dream," but the same stage contains both.

3.4 Bakhtin: The Carnivalesque

The Russian thinker Mikhail Bakhtin (1895–1975) analysed, through his conception of the carnivalesque, moments in culture when established hierarchies are overturned, social boundaries are breached, and popular laughter mocks authority.

The play contains many carnivalesque moments. Budhiraj, the "witless minister," and Bhunbhunadev, the muttering or humming subedar, have names that themselves ridicule the authority of their offices. When the thieves decide who will lead them through a democratic counting of votes, political manoeuvring enters even this lawless group. They become a carnivalesque state in miniature.

In Bakhtinian terms, the gamchha episode also inverts hierarchy. Having ridiculed sovereign power and its court, the bhats establish a direct economic relationship with their spectators without a royal intermediary. This carnivalesque action stages the conflict between patronage by the state and support from the people.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Li Yu: Principles of Dramatic Construction

The Chinese playwright and critic Li Yu (1611–1680), whose Xianqing Ouji, often translated as Casual Expressions of Idle Feeling, is a foundational work of Chinese dramatic criticism, proposed the notion of zhunao, the central

governing idea or "principal brain" of a play. A successful drama should possess a central axis around which all its narrative strands are gathered.

The zhunao of the present play is "intelligence versus physical force," together with the related conflict of popular art versus state power. Li Yu holds that the governing idea should be established in the first act, and this is precisely what Kunal accomplishes in the opening scene with the bhats.

Li Yu's second principle, mizhenxian, or fine stitching, concerns the joining of all parts of a play so that every thread finds its place by the end. The gamchha episode and the return to the bhats' outer frame exemplify this principle. The external narrative of the performers' crisis closes at the very point from which it began.

4.2 The Chou Character Type

In classical Chinese theatre, including jingju or Peking opera and related forms, character types are conventionally described here as sheng (male lead), dan (female role), jing (painted face), mo (elder), and chou (clown). The chou is distinguished by the ability to address spectators directly, disrupt stage conventions, and speak in a vernacular idiom.

The three bhats represent a threefold version of the chou. Their audience address, abandonment of roles, songs, and self-ridicule are all characteristic of this theatrical type. The parallel suggests a more general principle of folk drama: performance traditions across cultures create a clown who breaks the fourth wall and invites society to look at itself.

4.3 Xu–Shi: The Aesthetics of Emptiness and Fulness

The relationship between xu and shi, the empty and the full, is fundamental to Chinese aesthetics. What remains empty on stage—the absence of physical scenery or objects—can be made full through imagination. A Chinese performer can evoke a boat with a stick, or an entire journey through a single step.

One affecting example in Kunal's play is Gonu's wad of cotton seeds. Gonu declares that a handful of otherwise worthless cotton seeds sells for ten gold coins per unit of weight. An "empty" object, lacking value, is transformed into a "full" and valuable commodity. This is an exercise of xu–shi through Gonu's intelligence. Kunal's aesthetic sensibility is thus consonant with the transformation of absence into imaginative abundance in Chinese popular theatre.

4.4 Yijing: Wang Guowei

The Chinese literary critic Wang Guowei (1877–1927), in Renjian Cihua, discusses yijing, the fusion of feeling and situation. In accomplished art, emotion and setting merge to create an autonomous aesthetic sphere.

The yijing of this play arises from the meeting of two contrary emotions: the nostalgia surrounding the bhats' dying art and the exuberance produced by Gonu's unconquerable intelligence. Together they create a theatrical atmosphere in which melancholy and delight coexist. Wang also discusses

youwo zhi jing, a landscape or realm marked by the subjective self, in which the creator's feeling merges with the represented world. Kunal's affection for Maithili performers and his concern for the crisis facing them are expressed throughout the collection in an analogous fashion.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Eli Rozik: Theatrical Iconicity

The Israeli theatre scholar Eli Rozik (born 1934), in Theatrical Image and subsequent writings, proposed that the fundamental unit of theatre is the image or icon, rather than the written text or story. Through bodily presence, voice, and action, performers create icons, in Peirce's sense, of a fictional world. Theatre is a system of such images.

Rozik's theory illuminates a particular aspect of this play: the image of the bhats. The three figures on stage represent more than three individual people. Together they present an image of the dying bardic tradition. Rozik distinguishes the iconic from the merely symbolic: the former depends upon a relation of resemblance to what it signifies. The bhats show the decline of their art, and that act of showing constitutes an iconic image.

When the bhats decide to make a play about their own predicament, theatre takes itself as its subject. Rozik's idea of "theatre about theatre" becomes applicable here. The medium represents its own medium: an effective instance of iconic self-reflection.

5.2 Shimon Levy: Theatre as Cultural Archive

The Israeli theatre scholar Shimon Levy (1939–2017) highlighted forms of performance through which theatre becomes a cultural archive, a living repository of traditions, memories, and practices that might otherwise be forgotten. In this perspective, theatre is not only an event in the present; it can also be a performance of a remembered past.

The bhat tradition, a centuries-old hereditary livelihood of praise-singers in Mithila, archives the moment of its decline upon the stage. What the audience witnesses is an image of the tradition's living moment of death. The 1993 Patna staging preserves a living example of bardic culture, even as the characters on stage lament its disappearance.

5.3 A Parallel with the Revival of Hebrew through Theatre

A major dimension of Israeli theatrical history has been the establishment of Hebrew as a language of living performance. Habima, founded in Moscow in 1917 and later established as Israel's national theatre, used Hebrew drama to give renewed theatrical life to a language often described at that historical moment as having been largely confined to literary and religious use.

Kunal's play and Bhangima's 1993 Patna performance invite a comparison. Within the Hindi-dominated cultural milieu of Patna, staging drama in Maithili is an act of language politics: a cultural and political assertion that

Maithili is not "merely a dialect" but a literary language fit for actors and audiences. In this sense Bhangima's role has affinities with that of Habima.

5.4 Witness Theatre: The Economics of the Gamchha

In Israeli theatrical practice, witness theatre has emerged as a mode in which performance bears witness to harsh social realities and calls on spectators to accept a responsibility towards what they have seen.

The final gamchha episode, when the bhats say openly that "our stomachs will be filled only if the audience shows kindness," becomes an act of witnessing. It makes public the economic vulnerability of performing artists and places the audience in the position of witnesses. This is more than a joke: it acknowledges a hard truth about art and the life of those who practise it.

From this perspective, the ending becomes a political act, an invitation to the audience to bear witness and accept responsibility.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis: Comparative Evaluation

Viewed through these four traditions together, Forty Thieves and Gonu Jha is a multilayered creation. It can be read through Indian theories of rasa and vakrokti, Brecht's distancing effect, Chinese xu–shi aesthetics, and Israeli witness theatre.

The Indian perspective: an unusual combination of comic and heroic rasa; a popular transformation of the vidushaka tradition; and the expansion of the meaning of "intelligence" through dhvani.

The Western perspective: a strikingly Brechtian epic-theatre structure, a classic example of metatheatre, and Bakhtinian carnivalesque inversions.

The Chinese perspective: the affinities between the bhats and the chou character type; the aesthetics of xu–shi; and the interplay of melancholy and joy associated with yijing.

The Israeli perspective: Rozik's iconic self-reflection; Levy's theatre as archive; the politics of language comparable with Habima; and the gamchha as an act of witnessing.

A conclusion common to all four perspectives is that this is not simply "the story of Gonu Jha" but the story of theatre itself: its crisis, its economics, its vitality, and its social obligations. In this respect the play is also a theatrical manifesto, declaring intelligence and the comic reasoning of folk performers to be the means of standing against every obstacle.

Chapter 3

Bidapat: A Theatrical Dialogue Between Folk and Classical Traditions

Vidyapati, Popular Memory, and a Multicultural Vision of Theatre

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1. Introduction and Dramatic Architecture

Kunal's second play, Bidapat—the popular pronunciation of Vidyapati—is the most accomplished work in the collection in terms of its formal diversity. Written in the manner of Bidapat Naach, the renowned folk-theatre tradition of Mithila and Bengal, the play is explicitly situated by its author between 1400 and 1450 CE. Yet Kunal's ambition extends further. Rather than merely writing a biographical drama, he constructs a theatrical commentary on Vidyapati's poetry.

The play's architecture operates on three levels. The outer level consists of the dialogue between the sutradhara and actress, the interruptions of the clown-like Vipata, and the classical performance of the purvaranga. The middle level is the enacted story of Vidyapati, Shiv Singh, Lakhima, Ugna, Mandakini, Kalindi, Amiyakar, and the courtiers. The inner level contains embedded performances of Vidyapati's own songs, which provide the story's emotional axis. The interaction of these three levels generates the play's theatrical energy.

The plot turns upon five principal axes: (1) the friendship of Vidyapati and Shiv Singh; (2) Shiv Singh's release from the court of the Sultan of Jaunpur through Vidyapati's poetic powers; (3) the inner tale of Ugna as Mahadeva; (4) Lakhima's resistance to conspiracy and Shiv Singh's disappearance; and (5) Vidyapati's thirty-two years of grief and his declaration of poetry's immortality. The triangle formed by the sutradhara, actress, and Vipata closes the outer frame around these five strands.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 Purvaranga and the Tradition of the Ten Dramatic Forms

Bharata's Natyashastra, dated here broadly between the second century BCE and the second century CE, gives a central place to purvaranga, the preliminary performance that includes an auspicious invocation, the sutradhara's entrance, and an introductory address. Kunal adopts this classical architecture while transforming it into a folk-theatrical mode. The sequence of invocation to the goddess, praise of Bhairavi, and the sutradhara's introduction follows the Natyashastra tradition.

Dhananjaya's tenth-century Dasharupaka distinguishes ten dramatic forms. Bidapat is described on its title page as a natika, a form that the present study associates with brevity, comedy, separation, and suffering on the part of both central characters. Bidapat fits this description only partly: it contains separation and tragedy, but compassion and sorrow replace the comic as its dominant mood. When Abhinavagupta discusses the natika, he calls for an exceptional hero; Vidyapati certainly fills that role.

2.2 The Realisation of Rasa: A Confluence of Karuna, Shringara, and Shanta

The dominant rasa of this play is karuna, the sentiment of sorrow: Shiv Singh's disappearance, Lakhima's thirty-two years of waiting, and Vidyapati's final isolation. Bharata identifies grief as the enduring emotional disposition underlying karuna, intensified through recollection of the lost beloved. Yet the play's sorrow moves towards the shanta rasa elucidated by Abhinavagupta. The concluding song of the chorus, which declares Vidyapati, Shiv Singh, Lakhima, and Vipata immortal in poetry, embodies the inward repose of tranquillity.

In his Abhinavabharati, his commentary on the Natyashastra, Abhinavagupta (c. 950–1020 CE) argues that rasa is manifested rather than literally brought into existence. It is already latent in the spectator's consciousness and is awakened by drama. In Bidapat, the use of Vidyapati's actual lyrics gives particular force to this manifestation: the performance reawakens the audience's dormant memory of its poetic heritage.

Shringara rasa flows through Vidyapati's lyrics, particularly "A new Vrindavan, ever-new groves, where the youthful lover plays" and "Shape a face from the essence of the moon." But this erotic sentiment is devotional rather than merely worldly; through the play of Radha and Krishna, it seeks an experience of universal love. Shringara and devotion thus fuse, forming a conjunction of erotic love and bhakti in Indian poetics.

2.3 The Theory of Dhvani: Three Meanings Within the Word "Bidapat"

The suggestive possibilities of the word Bidapat are extraordinary. Through Anandavardhana's theory of dhvani, at least three levels of meaning may be discerned in this one word: (a) Vidyapati, the poet himself, as the literal referent; (b) Bidapat Naach, the name of a folk-theatrical tradition, as an associated meaning—although the tradition and the earlier Vidyapati associated with Jyotirishwar precede the particular period 1400–1450; and (c) a suggested play on bida, farewell, and pat, lord or one who departs. This last possibility anticipates the sorrowful ending, Shiv Singh's disappearance, and the farewell to an age. The threefold suggestiveness demonstrates the playwright's linguistic awareness.

There is also an instance of obliqueness in naming: "Vidyapati, Vidyapati!" confronts "Bidapat is Bidapat!" The sutradhara insists on the classical name, while Vipata stubbornly retains the popular pronunciation. Their dispute is a comic dramatisation of a deeper cultural tension between classical authority and popular practice, even though both names refer to the same person.

2.4 Drama Within Drama

Although the Natyashastra does not distinguish "drama within drama" as an independent genre, Sanskrit plays contain analogous practices, such as dream sequences in Bhasa or performed episodes in Ratnavali. Bidapat includes two distinct embedded performances. First is Amiyakar's swang, or comic impersonation, in which he enacts the meeting between Vidyapati and the Sultan, shifting from one role to another while eating sweets. This is an indigenous form of performative storytelling. Second is the embedded scene featuring Gaura, Mahadeva, and Natua, in which Gaura laments Shiva's poverty. It prepares the dramatic revelation of Ugna's identity as Mahadeva.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Georg Lukacs: Historical Drama and the World-Historical Individual

The Hungarian Marxist critic Georg Lukacs (1885–1971) offered a criterion for historical drama: the protagonist should be a world-historical individual, one who embodies the contradictions of an epoch in his own life. Vidyapati can be viewed as just such a figure. On the one hand, he lives within a dependent political order, amid Tirhut's subordination to Jaunpur. On the other, he trusts in a poetic power that exceeds political authority. His life gives bodily expression to this contradiction.

Yet Kunal's Vidyapati is not the triumphant protagonist of a conventional Lukacsian model. He is a grieving witness. Shiv Singh's disappearance ends the relationship that had given the poet's life its deepest meaning. The tranquillity attained after thirty-two years of waiting differs from the predicament of a Western tragic hero: it suggests a contemplative, inward tragedy.

3.2 A Feminist Reading: Lakhima as Heroine

Western feminist approaches to drama, associated here with critics such as Kate Millett, Ellen Morton, and Sharon Friedman, have paid particular attention to rereading works in which women are marginalised beneath the shadow of celebrated historical men. Kunal consciously reverses this tendency.

Lakhima is notable from a feminist perspective for three reasons. First, she refuses the protection offered by ministers and interprets the conspiracy herself: "They see an opportunity to break apart the triad of king, queen, and great poet." Second, her waiting is not the passivity of a conventional devoted wife, but an act of freely chosen resolve. Third, where inherited narratives frequently place Lakhima at the centre of a sati legend, Kunal turns away from that framework and places her continuing life and waiting at the centre.

3.3 Pierre Nora: Sites of Memory

The French historian Pierre Nora (born 1931), in Les Lieux de mémoire, developed the concept of sites of memory: places, objects, and texts in which collective historical memory is deposited and made active.

Vidyapati's lyrics function as important sites of memory in this play. When the chorus sings "A new Vrindavan, ever-new groves, where the youthful lover

plays," or when Shiv Singh's song "O bumblebee, it is for you that I …" arises in Lakhima's memory, these moments are simultaneously recollections of history and experiences in the present. The staging transforms six centuries of distance into an immediate theatrical moment. Bidapat is thus not merely a drama about Vidyapati; it is a performance of the collective memory of the Maithili-speaking community.

3.4 Brecht and Self-Distancing: The Role of Vipata

The role played by the three bhats in the first drama is assumed here by the triangle of sutradhara, actress, and Vipata. Vipata's incessant demand to "Move the story along!" provides a precise indigenous variation on a Brechtian distancing effect. It prevents spectators from being entirely absorbed in the story and continually reminds them that the dramatic world has been constructed.

There is, however, an important distinction from Brecht. The German dramatist sought to awaken the critical intelligence of his spectators; Vipata's interruptions stir exhilaration more than analysis. He is a folk agent of distancing who brings the elite dignity of art down to the accessible level of the gari, the bullock cart, and the khissa, the tale. This aesthetic difference helps establish the originality of the play in relation to Western theatrical theory.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Caizi–Jiaren: The Scholar and the Beauty

A major dramatic pattern in classical Chinese theatre, particularly the kunqu opera of the Ming and Qing periods, is caizi–jiaren, the story of a brilliant scholar encountering a beautiful woman. Through the romance of a learned poet and a beautiful heroine, such plays affirm the force of poetry and the value of love.

Bidapat offers a displaced version of this pattern. Vidyapati is the caizi, a man distinguished by poetic talent rather than mere logical skill; Lakhima is no conventional jiaren, but a queen with a strong sense of dignity. Yet their relationship contains the profound trust, friendship, and affection central to the pattern. Shiv Singh's disappearance transforms it into a triangle: at its centre stood a third person who is now absent.

4.2 Zhiyin: Perfect Understanding and Its Absence

In the Chinese cultural tradition, zhiyin is a profound relationship with someone who truly hears and understands an artist's work. According to a famous legend, the zither player Bo Ya broke his instrument after the death of his only true listener, Zhong Ziqi: "The one who could hear is gone; why should I play?"

The relationship between Vidyapati and Shiv Singh embodies this ideal of zhiyin. Shiv Singh was the supreme listener, appreciator, and patron of Vidyapati's poetry. His disappearance leaves the poet's artistic life almost

orphaned. "Ugna, where have you gone?" becomes a lament for the loss of perfect understanding. As with Bo Ya's broken zither, the sound of Vidyapati's poetry is suffused with grief.

4.3 Zhezixi and Layered Performance

The Chinese folk-theatre tradition of zhezixi, or excerpt plays, selects self-contained episodes from expansive dramatic cycles for separate performance. Three distinct passages of this kind can be identified in Bidapat: (a) Amiyakar's impersonation of the encounter at the Sultan's court; (b) the embedded play of Gaura, Mahadeva, and Natua, preparing the revelation of Ugna; and (c) the Radha–Krishna rasa performed by the sutradhara and actress in the preliminary sequence.

Such layered performance keeps several narrative planes active on the same stage. Chinese dramaturgy describes drama within drama as xizhongxi. Indian theatre possesses analogous forms of enacted episodes within a play, while the Chinese formulation makes the levels of performance especially explicit.

4.4 Bei–Huan–Li–He: Four Fundamental Dramatic Conditions

The Chinese dramatic tradition is here understood through four recurring emotional conditions: bei, sorrow; huan, joy; li, separation; and he, reunion. An accomplished play can bring all four into the movement of a single narrative.

All four are present in Bidapat: huan in victory and celebration at Oini; li in Shiv Singh's disappearance; bei in the thirty-two years of grief endured by Vidyapati and Lakhima; and he in the reunion achieved through poetry, a spiritual and invisible reunion in which Vidyapati declares Shiv Singh immortal in his songs. This reunion is not worldly but inward, extending the Chinese pattern into another possibility.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 S. Ansky's The Dybbuk: The Theatrical Presence of a Dead Beloved

The Jewish-Russian playwright S. Ansky (1863–1920) wrote The Dybbuk, also known as Between Two Worlds, first staged in 1920 and regarded as a foundational work of Yiddish and Hebrew theatre. In the play, the soul of a dead lover enters the body of the woman he loved and becomes present on stage. Its governing insight is that love can be stronger than death.

In Bidapat, Shiv Singh disappears bodily from the stage, yet his continuing presence in Lakhima's memory acquires a dybbuk-like theatrical reality. When his song "O bumblebee, it is for you that I …" is sung and his shadowy figure appears, the dramatic logic is comparable to that of The Dybbuk. In both plays the emotional truth of love crosses the boundary of death.

5.2 Eli Rozik: The Iconic Presence of the Lyric

Eli Rozik's theory of iconicity allows theatrical images to arise not only from the performer's body but also from sound. When the samaji chorus sings

Vidyapati's lyrics, a song becomes a sound-icon: not merely music, but a theatrical image of the poet's entire world of experience.

Rozik's distinction between the theatrical image and the dramatic text is relevant here. Kunal's written script and the embodied, vocal, and gestural image of the actors singing Vidyapati's songs are distinct realities. In this play they exist in productive tension. Kunal's script incorporates Vidyapati's songs, but the songs continually exceed the script's control and live their independent poetic lives.

5.3 Beyond Habima's Language Politics: The Rebirth of Poetic Language

In the discussion of the preceding play, we observed affinities between Bhangima's language politics and those of Habima Theatre. In Bidapat this parallel develops another layer: the revival not merely of a language, but of its poetic language. The theatrical revival of Hebrew also has connections to efforts to sustain a Hebrew poetic tradition in performance.

The 2002 staging of Bidapat at Vidyapati Bhavan, Patna, gave renewed theatrical life to Vidyapati's songs, which risked being treated as objects confined to libraries. In this sense Bhangima's endeavour constitutes a theatrical rebirth of poetic language, comparable to the revitalisation of Hebrew poetry in Israeli theatre.

5.4 A Postcolonial Perspective: The Diplomatic Power of Poetry

In postcolonial theatrical scholarship associated with the Israeli scholar Avraham Oz and others, particular attention is paid to performances in which cultural power contests and defeats political or military power.

The Sultan's court episode in Bidapat is an exemplary case. The Sultan of Jaunpur embodies political sovereignty; Vidyapati embodies cultural authority. The poet secures Shiv Singh's release not through ordinary diplomacy but by composing and performing verse, including his description of a bathing scene while deprived of sight. When the Sultan invites him to ask for anything, Vidyapati requests his friend's freedom rather than a throne. A minister remarks, "If only he had asked for the kingdom of Tirhut!" Vidyapati replies, "But truly, I have already received a kingdom!" This is a declaration of the victory of poetry over colonial or imperial power.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis

When these four traditions are brought together, the central question of Bidapat becomes clear: what is the power of poetry, and through what forms does it assert its existence? Each tradition approaches the answer from a different direction.

The Indian perspective: the power of poetry lies in the manifestation of rasa. Lyrics awaken emotion already latent within the spectator. At its culmination in shanta rasa, poetry triumphs over death.

The Western perspective: poetic power is understood through sites of memory (Nora), the expression of a world-historical individual (Lukacs), and a feminist rereading centred on Lakhima.

The Chinese perspective: poetic power is the art of zhiyin, perfect understanding, and the spiritual reunion that completes bei–huan–li–he.

The Israeli perspective: poetic power lies in the autonomous iconic presence of sound (Rozik) and the cultural and diplomatic victory of poetry over colonial or imperial rule.

All four perspectives converge on the proposition that Vidyapati's lyrics are not simply literary compositions but living cultural and political forces. Kunal makes this power live again through theatre. Bidapat is therefore more than a play about Vidyapati: it is a declaration of the existence and vitality of Maithili theatre itself.

Chapter 4

Kusma-Salhes: Folk Epic and Popular Consciousness

Salhes Naach, Love, and the Freedom of the People's Hero

First staged: 29–30 April 1997, Vidyapati Bhavan, Patna · Published: Antika, April–September 2006

1. Introduction, Plot Structure, and Historical-Cultural Context

Kunal's third and most expansive drama, Kusma-Salhes, occupies the central place in the collection. At approximately seventy pages, it is the collection's artistic, intellectual, and cultural centre. Its foundation is the epic of Raja Salhes, the folk-deity and hero of Mithila's Dusadh community, and the folk-theatrical tradition of Salhes Naach that developed around this epic.

The geography of the story is vast: Mahisautha, Morang, Baghgarh, Rewa-Dah, Bhot or Tibet, Samdagarh, Pakariya, Garh-Taregana, and Rangilagarh form a geopolitical world extending across India, Nepal, and Tibet. The cast is equally epic: Salhes, the hero; Kusma, the gardener heroine; Hiraman, the parrot who carries the story; Vipata, the clown; Thanka, the tiger; Banka, the bear; Kunta, the forest dweller; the goddess Durga; and numerous kings, armies, and adversaries.

The dramatic action unfolds in five major movements: (1) a preliminary performance, including a syncretic invocation and a metatheatrical beginning led by Vipata and Hiraman; (2) Kusma's introduction and spiritual purification; (3) Salhes's valour, their first meeting, and Durga's blessing; (4) the invasion from Bhot, conspiracy, and imprisonment; and (5) a declaration of freedom, victory through popular solidarity, and the final affirmation of love as a principle of existence.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 Salhes Naach: An Autonomous Aesthetic of Folk Theatre

Bharata's Natyashastra develops its theory of drama within the Sanskritic tradition. Mithila's Salhes Naach, however, possesses an autonomous grammar of performance. Its distinctive elements include the collective song of the samaji chorus; the sumiran, a folk invocation calling simultaneously upon Hindu, Muslim, and indigenous deities; Vipata as clown; Hiraman the parrot as carrier of narrative; and the acclamations that precede Salhes's entrance. These are the ritual and performative conventions of this particular theatrical world.

Kunal adopts this whole folk grammar with fidelity. The ritual purification, the sequence of events, the singing, and the modes of address follow their inherited performance contexts. The result is not an elite imitation of folk theatre but a literary re-presentation of the folk form itself. Recognising this distinction is essential.

2.2 A Festival of Rasa: The Many-Coloured Emotional Structure

In Sanskrit poetics, the ideal dramatic work is commonly conceived as possessing a dominant rasa to which other rasas contribute. The complexity of Kusma-Salhes lies in the presence of not one singular governing sentiment but a veritable festival of rasa.

There is shringara, in the love of Kusma and Salhes, a popular counterpart to Radha and Krishna—"He is Krishna Gosain, and you are Radha Rani"; vira, in Salhes's martial courage and mercy towards a defeated enemy—"It would be wrong to pursue and harry an army retreating in defeat"; adbhuta, the marvellous, in the supernatural presence of Thanka, Banka, Hiraman, and Durga; karuna, compassion and sorrow, in the seemingly impossible love between the already-married Salhes and Kusma, constrained by caste boundaries; bhakti, devotion to Durga and the interreligious accommodation of the sumiran; and bibhatsa and bhayanaka, revulsion and fear, in Suchong's plots and the cruelties of imprisonment.

Bharata allows for a combination in which an angi rasa, the principal sentiment, and supporting anga rasas generate a complex emotional experience. Here shringara and vira almost become coequal principal sentiments. Durga's declaration brings them together: "Having joined with Kusma, move now among the minds of the people; dedicate your life solely to their happiness." Love becomes the very source of heroic obligation.

2.3 A Subaltern Aesthetic: Against the Canon

The classical hero in Sanskrit dramaturgy commonly comes from the lineage of royal sages or divine families. The Dusadh hero does not occupy that privileged position within the established conventions. Kunal's boldest dramatic decision is to place the epic of a socially subordinated community at the centre of an epic theatre work.

In the tradition of Vidyapati, love poetry has often given prominence to Radha and Krishna or to Shiv Singh and Lakhima. Kunal chooses another path: Kusma becomes a popular "Radhiya," while Salhes assumes the role of "Krishna Gosain." This symbolic substitution makes a dramatic claim that the love story of the Dusadh tradition is equal to—and perhaps lies at the roots of—the mainstream of Maithili literature.

2.4 Kusma's Inner Purification: An Indigenous Practice of Yoga

A striking sequence of inner purification occurs in the dialogue between Hiraman and Kusma in the second scene. It is a folk transformation of yogic discipline: "Sweep your own house … I have swept out jealousy, pride, hatred, greed, and delusion … I have plastered it with the water of compassion … and perfumed it with the sandalwood of affection." The cleansing is not a physical action but an emotional and spiritual journey inward. Indian philosophical traditions, especially bhakti, treat purification of the heart or consciousness as a condition for the realisation of love.

Kunal presents this devotional philosophy in a comic register. Hiraman first demands a reward—gold, a diamond necklace, a silver bowl—and only then offers his guidance. The popular humour does not trivialise the philosophical idea; it makes it alive.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Gramsci: Subaltern History and the Organic Intellectual

In his Prison Notebooks, the Italian Marxist thinker Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937) examined the history of subaltern groups as an alternative to hegemonic historical writing. His "organic intellectual" is someone who brings the cultural expression of a particular community into an articulated literary or intellectual form.

From this perspective, Kunal is an organic intellectual of Maithili theatre. He takes the Dusadh epic of Salhes, previously sustained principally within the community performance tradition of Salhes Naach, and brings it to the modern stage of Vidyapati Bhavan. Such cultural translation is political in Gramsci's sense: a subaltern voice enters a central space of cultural authority.

Salhes's prison speech is the most significant moment from this perspective: "My life may be in your fist, Emperor. But my thoughts and feelings cannot be bound." This statement gives a folk-theatrical form to the strategies of resistance against cultural hegemony that Gramsci theorised.

3.2 Magical Realism: The Presence of Folk Belief on Stage

The Colombian writer Gabriel Garcia Marquez (1927–2014) and the Indian-British novelist Salman Rushdie (born 1947) have used magical realism to present extraordinary or supernatural elements as ordinary components of reality, without requiring special explanations or expressions of amazement.

In Kusma-Salhes, the tiger Thanka and the bear Banka converse with Salhes; Hiraman the parrot carries messages between heaven and earth; and

Durga appears before the people's hero to bless him. These are natural features of the Dusadh folk cosmology, not "miracles" imported into an otherwise ordinary world. In terms of magical realism, it is more precise to call them "folk-cosmological realities" than merely "magical" elements.

An important proposition associated here with Rushdie is that magical realism is effective when the extraordinary is experienced as real from within the author's represented world, rather than imposed as an exotic ornament by an outside observer. Kunal's play has this authenticity. Thanka, Banka, Hiraman, and Durga are necessary to the story's structure, not decorative additions.

3.3 Brecht: The Lehrstuck and Popular Politics

Through his idea of the Lehrstuck, or learning play, Brecht recognised theatre's capacity to convey an explicit ethical and political understanding. Kusma-Salhes contains several instructive moments through the chorus and through Hiraman and Vipata: Salhes's teaching of life without fear and Durga's instruction to dedicate oneself to the people's welfare.

Kunal nevertheless differs from Brecht in one important respect. Brecht sought distance from emotional identification, whereas Kunal regards love and public service as inseparable. The intellectual and political education associated with the Lehrstuck is immersed here in erotic feeling and devotional rasa. This produces a kind of "emotional epic theatre" that exceeds a narrowly Brechtian category.

3.4 Homi Bhabha: Cultural Identity and Resistance

In The Location of Culture, the Indian-British postcolonial thinker Homi Bhabha (born 1949) developed notions such as the third space and cultural hybridity, through which a colonised people can appropriate and destabilise the discourse of colonial power.

Suchong's conspiracy to separate Salhes from Kusma can be interpreted as a strategy of domination. He understands that Kusma's affection and knowledge are sources of Salhes's strength and that separating them will weaken him. This resembles the erasure of cultural identity by which colonial power seeks to destroy a community's capacity for resistance. Salhes recognises the strategy and declares that thought and feeling cannot be imprisoned.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Yi: Righteous Conduct and the Ethics of War

Yi, righteousness or duty, is a central value in Chinese moral philosophy, especially in the Confucian tradition, where it means performing one's obligations properly even when doing so is difficult. The celebrated hero Guan Yu, or Guan Di, of Chinese popular drama is renowned for his practice of yi, including his respect for defeated opponents.

Salhes displays precisely this conduct: "It is improper to harry an army that is fleeing after defeat." This is not merely tactical prudence but a principle of

ethical conduct in war, consonant with both Indian kshatriya dharma and Chinese yi. Like Guan Yu, Salhes becomes a popular deity not simply through acts of battle but through his place in the people's hearts.

4.2 Hualian: Character Types and Colour Symbolism

In classical Chinese theatre, including jingju or Beijing opera, the hualian, or painted-face role, uses the colours of facial makeup to indicate moral and psychological qualities. Red may signify courage and loyalty, as with Guan Yu; blue or green, formidable strength; white, cunning and treachery; and black, power or uprightness.

This symbolic system can be applied comparatively to the characters of Kusma-Salhes. Salhes corresponds to a red hualian, for valour and loyalty; Suchong to white, for intrigue and deception; Chuharmall to blue, for military force; Kusma to the dan female role, but a powerful one, associated with the forest goddess; Hiraman and Vipata to the chou clown; and Durga to a divine manifestation, shenming. The comparison reveals a widely recognisable theatrical logic in the play's ordering of character types.

4.3 Tianming: The Mandate of Heaven and the Hero's Duty

Tianming, the Mandate of Heaven, is an important concept in Chinese political thought. A ruler who works for the well-being of his subjects possesses Heaven's mandate; one who corrupts that obligation loses it.

Durga's blessing corresponds to tianming in this play. She commands Salhes to dedicate his life solely to the happiness of the people, thereby legitimising his authority as a ruler. Suchong, in contrast, is expansionist, greedy, and oppressive; he has forfeited the moral right to such a mandate. Kunal's play presents Salhes's final victory as the outcome not simply of military strength but of moral and popular power.

4.4 Minjian: The Dramatisation of Folk Heroes

Chinese theatre has a long tradition of turning popular heroes and temple deities into protagonists of drama, including the performance cycles described here as temple-hero legends. The relation between Salhes Naach and Kunal's play follows an analogous trajectory: a folk deity first becomes a hero of community performance and then enters literary theatre.

The comparable Chinese movement runs from legends surrounding Guan Yu through Romance of the Three Kingdoms and into theatrical adaptations. The journey from the Salhes epic through Salhes Naach to Kunal's Kusma-Salhes, published in 2006, expresses a similar cycle of cultural life.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Eli Rozik: The Theatrical Iconicity of Animal Characters

Eli Rozik's theory of theatrical iconicity encounters an extraordinary test in the animal characters of this play. Thanka the tiger, Banka the bear, and Hiraman the parrot are represented on stage by human performers. In Rozik's

terms, these are icons: the image they show resembles fictional animal life rather than merely the actor's human body.

More importantly, the stage can cross the boundary between human and animal because the icon is not constrained by the actual nature of the performer. The presence of Thanka, Banka, and Hiraman creates an animistic iconography of Dusadh folk belief, a worldview in which people, animals, and spirits coexist as active presences within a single dramatic world. This is a form of "transgressive iconicity."

5.2 A Parallel with Mizrahi Theatre: Recovering Marginalised Traditions

In Israeli theatre, the cultural traditions of Mizrahi Jews, whose origins lie in the Middle East and North Africa, were long marginalised by dominant Ashkenazi or European Jewish norms. The movement towards Mizrahi theatrical expression, particularly from the 1970s onward, has sought to restore musical and cultural forms associated with these communities, including Sephardi musical traditions and liturgical songs, to public prominence.

Kunal's Kusma-Salhes may be viewed as a comparable intervention within the Maithili context. The Dusadh tradition of Salhes Naach remained at the margins of a cultural hierarchy dominated by Vidyapati, Chanda Jha, and elite literary traditions. By taking this marginalised inheritance onto the stage of Vidyapati Bhavan, a central institution of Maithili cultural life, Kunal makes an unmistakable cultural and political claim.

5.3 Hannah Arendt: Natality and Public Action

In The Human Condition, the German-American political philosopher Hannah Arendt (1906–1975) developed the concept of natality: every political act is a new beginning, a kind of birth. Action in the public realm gains endurance because there are witnesses to it.

Salhes's prison declaration—"Salhes may cease to exist, but the people, filled with the message of a life free from fear, will remain"—is an instance of political action in Arendt's sense. Spoken in Suchong's prison, with the emperor himself as witness, it acquires a form of permanence. It is a theatrical moment of natality. Through the scene, Kunal transforms Salhes from folk deity into a figure of political action.

5.4 Shimon Levy: Syncretic Invocation and Sacred Theatre

In his writing on sacred theatre, Shimon Levy examines how the performance of communal and religious values on stage can function as a secular transformation of ritual practice.

The sumiran of this play's opening performance provides an especially striking case. It is not solely a Hindu religious invocation, for it also includes the Muslim pir Mira-Sultan, associated with the west. "Pranam, namaste, adaab, good evening, salaam": this address to spectators crosses boundaries of religion, language, class, and national belonging in one breath. Viewed through Levy's framework, it constitutes a form of radically inclusive sacred theatre, rejecting divisive identities and imagining a shared community.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis

As the title play of the collection, Kusma-Salhes is simultaneously the most fertile and most challenging work for comparative study across these four traditions. No single critical framework can exhaust its many dimensions.

The Indian perspective: the autonomous performance grammar of Salhes Naach; the festival of rasas—shringara, vira, bhakti, and adbhuta; the staging of a subaltern aesthetic; and Durga's blessing as the declaration that love, knowledge, and service to the people are inseparable.

The Western perspective: Gramsci's organic intellectual; an authentic folk version of magical realism; an emotionally charged variation of Brechtian epic theatre; and Bhabha's account of resistance through cultural identity.

The Chinese perspective: the ethics of yi, comparable to Guan Yu; the hualian system of character types; tianming in Durga's heavenly command; and the dramatic transformation of folk heroes within the minjian tradition.

The Israeli perspective: Rozik's transgressive animistic iconicity; the cultural parallel with Mizrahi theatre; Arendt's natality, with the prison speech as a political birth; and Levy's radical sacred dimension in the sumiran.

The shared conclusion of these four traditions is that the play performs an act of cultural justice. It brings the Dusadh hero Salhes into the centre of the Maithili literary stage, makes folk theatre the foundation of written drama, and affirms love and service to the people as inseparable principles. Taken together, these actions are presented as valuable and necessary within Indian, Western, Chinese, and Israeli frames of theatrical thought.

The final refrain completes the drama: "Love is truth, love is fragrance, the feeling of love is everlasting; as a flower without nectar, so what is life without love?" All the preceding critical arguments lead towards these words. They constitute a declaration of the soul of the collection itself.

Chapter 5

The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory!

Women's Self-Determination and the Vow of Love

Published: Antika, April–June 2013 · Stage: three levels · Cast: two male and two female actors

1. Introduction, Dramatic Architecture, and Central Questions

The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory!, the first play in the quartet of love, marks a new turn in Kunal's dramatic writing. In contrast to the populous, song-and-dance-filled expansiveness of the folk-theatre trilogy, this play is economical, concentrated, and driven by ideas. The stage directions specify "a three-level stage, with levels used at times as platforms and at others

as steps." There are only four performers, two men and two women, who undertake multiple roles: Bharadvaja, the old man, Vashishtha, and Indra are shared between the male actors, while Shruvavati, her friend, and other women's roles are played by the actresses.

The source is a Puranic narrative concerning Shruvavati, daughter of the sage Bharadvaja, who appears in various mythological accounts. Kunal's Shruvavati, however, reaches far beyond the inherited story. She does not simply reject the conventional role of a daughter of marriageable age; she claims the right to determine the conditions of marriage: "The moment someone becomes meaningful to me, I shall marry!" The demand for meaningfulness is the drama's central philosophical and theatrical question.

The play has five movements: (1) Shruvavati's assertion of her independence and self-reliance before Bharadvaja; (2) her experience of love through Indra's shadow at the riverbank; (3) Indra's open appearance and invitation to enter heaven after death, which she refuses; (4) the tests set by Indra in the disguises of an old man and Vashishtha, involving a miraculous fruit that turns into stone; and (5) Shruvavati's resolve to enter the pyre, Indra's acceptance, and a conclusion marked by a couplet from Dushyant Kumar.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 The Classical Form of the Short Play and the Arrangement of Acts

The Natyashastra distinguishes dramatic forms according to extent and structure. Within the tradition of the Dasharupaka, the natika is presented here as a relatively short, heroine-centred drama involving a principal romance and an element of sorrow. The word "or" in the present title combines elite and popular traditions: The Vow of Love names a classical emotional value, while Shruvavati's Victory! has the force of a popular exclamation.

The use of a three-level stage may be read as a modern transformation of the Natyashastra's concept of the rangamandapa. Bharata describes divisions associated with the rangashirsha, the rangapitha, and the backstage area. Kunal's arrangement reinterprets these levels: the highest for male narrators or the sutradhara, the middle for the principal dramatic episodes, and the lower for the natural world of vegetation and riverbanks.

2.2 Rasa: Three Expressions of Shringara Together

Three varieties of shringara rasa coexist in this play: (a) love in union, in the initial attraction and the vision of a shadow by the river; (b) love in separation, in Indra's repeated refusals and Shruvavati's painful waiting; and (c) devotional love, in the making of a garland "to place upon the deity of my heart." Bharata identifies rati, loving attachment, as the enduring emotion of shringara. At its highest level, this can be understood as a purified love transcending the senses. Shruvavati is an embodiment of that aspiration.

Karuna rasa also has a distinctive presence: "What use is a heart that contains no memory of the beloved?" This is not simply an expression of grief but a philosophical sorrow in which the value of life is itself brought into question. The concluding scene also contains an element of shanta rasa, a quiet acceptance beyond all the relationships of ordinary life.

2.3 Dharmashastra and Female Autonomy: A Political Reading of the Drama

A familiar passage from the Manusmriti—"The father protects in childhood, the husband in youth"—assigns the responsibility of protecting a woman to male relations. Bharadvaja upholds this convention: "A woman should live with her brother, father, or husband." Shruvavati counters the entire norm with a question: "Why? Can I not protect and care for myself, Father?"

The cultural importance of this question is remarkable. It reaches beyond a demand for personal independence to challenge a dharmashastric norm from within Maithili mythological drama itself. Bharadvaja's final response—"May you be happy, whether as a householder or an ascetic"—concedes her right to choose. Patriarchal authority yields at this dramatic moment, which follows upon a tradition of women-centred intellectual and literary figures such as Maitreyi, Gargi, and Shakuntala.

2.4 Vakrokti: The Many-Layered Suggestiveness of "Meaningful"

From the perspectives of both Kuntaka's vakrokti and Anandavardhana's dhvani, the word "meaningful" is the most important term in the play. Literally it means important or useful; by extension, someone who lives a purposeful life; by suggestion, someone whose presence gives meaning to my own existence. The third meaning is the philosophical soul of the drama. Shruvavati seeks not outward qualifications such as beauty, wealth, or valour, but an intimate relationship of meaning.

The irony is that Indra, king of the gods, immensely powerful, already married, and lord of heaven, fails the test of becoming "meaningful" to a sage's daughter. Only at the scene of the pyre does he finally prove himself. The reversal combines oblique expression with satire.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Simone de Beauvoir: The Second Sex and Female Agency

The French philosopher and feminist Simone de Beauvoir (1908–1986) famously argued in The Second Sex (1949): "One is not born, but rather becomes, a woman." Her account treats the positioning of woman as "Other" as a social and cultural construction.

Shruvavati is a mythological dramatic example of this contention. Her father's protection, marriage proposals from royal families, and Indra's invitation for life "after death" all seek in different ways to turn her into an object of others' arrangements. At each stage she refuses and claims the position of an acting subject. Her final words—"I had accepted you all along,

beloved! Now you say so yourself!"—represent the culmination of that agency. The victory is hers.

3.2 Sartre: Existentialism and the Creation of Meaning

The French philosopher Jean-Paul Sartre (1905–1980) made "existence precedes essence" the central proposition of his existentialism. Human beings do not arrive with a predetermined essence; they define themselves through free decisions.

Shruvavati's position offers a mythological parallel to Sartrean existentialism. To be a sage's daughter is an identity given by birth; to be an "independent and self-reliant person" is an identity she claims and creates. "You yourself have said that exceptions prove the rule. Let me be an exception, Father!" expresses a kind of radical freedom in Maithili dramatic language.

Sartre uses mauvaise foi, or bad faith, for the refusal to acknowledge one's freedom and the retreat into prescribed roles. Indra's succession of disguises, as an old man and as Vashishtha, offers a divine variation on evasive self-presentation: the king of the gods hides his actual identity while administering tests. Shruvavati breaks through each disguise: "I was married from the moment I gave you a place in my heart."

3.3 Bakhtin: Polyphonic Drama and Dialogism

Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of dialogism treats language as inherently populated by different voices, with multiple discourses reverberating through individual utterances. The play's most notable example of such dialogism occurs in its final Urdu couplet.

Dushyant Kumar's (1931–1975) celebrated lines—"Who says a hole cannot be made in the sky? / Throw a stone with all your strength, friends"—appear suddenly at the end of a Maithili mythological play. Three linguistic and cultural registers meet in this polyphonic conclusion: Maithili myth, Hindi–Urdu poetic tradition, and modern political consciousness, in which piercing the sky signifies making the impossible possible. This is a distinctive theatrical instance of Bakhtinian heteroglossia.

3.4 Peter Brook: The Empty Stage and Theatrical Economy

In The Empty Space (1968), the British director Peter Brook (1925–2022) famously suggested that one person crossing an empty space while another watches is enough to constitute theatre. His concept of holy theatre also directs attention to what can be suggested rather than materially represented, allowing the spectator's imagination to participate.

The three-level empty stage of this play is a Maithili mythological counterpart to Brook's empty space. The levels become platforms or stairs according to need: the design offers possibilities of space rather than a mass of scenery. Indra's disappearances and returns, the fruit turning into stone, and the creation of the pyre can all be realised through changes in light and the performer's actions rather than elaborate sets. This is the realm of Brook's holy theatre, in which the spectator's inward attention becomes active.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Yuanfen: Predestined Love and Shruvavati's Challenge

In Chinese cultural thought, yuanfen denotes an affinity or bond of fate that brings two people together, often imagined as a preordained thread linking two souls. Many poetic dramas seek its fulfilment.

The relationship between Shruvavati and Indra gives yuanfen a complicated form. She calls Indra the "deity of her heart" and makes a garland for him, acknowledging the bond. Yet she rejects his condition of union only "after death" and therefore redefines what that bond means. Fate may bring two people together, she suggests, but a woman can determine the time and conditions of their relationship. This is a subtle assertion of agency.

4.2 Kaoyan: The Dramatic Tradition of the Trial

Kaoyan, the test or trial, is a familiar device in classical Chinese drama. Folk narratives frequently require a lover's loyalty to be demonstrated through an extraordinary ordeal. The dramatic tradition of Liang Zhu, or The Butterfly Lovers, likewise gives great importance to tests of fidelity.

In Kunal's play, the conventional structure of the trial is reversed. Instead of the hero being tested, Shruvavati is subjected to Indra's fruit test; yet the examiner himself is tested when her resolve to enter the pyre unsettles him. The examiner becomes the one examined. This reversal testifies to the play's originality.

4.3 Yizhi: Moral Will in Neo-Confucian Ethics

Neo-Confucian thinkers, particularly Wang Yangming (1472–1529), emphasised moral will, yizhi, and the extension of innate moral knowledge, zhi liangzhi. They understood moral knowing as something fundamentally available within human beings rather than simply imposed from outside.

Shruvavati may be regarded as a character endowed with such moral will. Her demand for meaningfulness, her denunciation of the disguised Indra as a man belonging to another woman, and her resolve at the pyre are not decisions taught to her by external authority. They arise from within. The play's assertion that "inner strength is a human being's greatest wealth" consequently bears a striking resemblance to Wang Yangming's moral philosophy.

4.4 Beiju: Chinese Tragedy and the "Victory" of This Play

Chinese dramatic criticism has debated whether classical Chinese theatre possesses beiju, tragedy in a specifically Western sense. Wang Guowei is presented here as observing that Chinese drama can involve painful circumstances while commonly moving towards accommodation or reconciliation. Such a pattern may be called a form of incomplete or qualified tragedy.

The "Victory!" of the title indicates that this play is not simply beiju, but an example of joy within sorrow. The hardening of the fruit and the resolve to

enter the pyre are painful; Indra's acknowledgement and the declaration of victory bring reconciliation. The crucial reversal is that the victor is Shruvavati, not Indra, lord of the gods.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Hanoch Levin: Dramatising the Defence of Human Dignity

The Israeli playwright Hanoch Levin (1943–1999) repeatedly explored the systems against which human dignity must be defended. In plays such as The Labour of Life, women often struggle to preserve their identity against familial and social pressures.

Shruvavati's circumstances resemble those of Levin's female characters, but with a significant difference. Levin's women frequently fail, overwhelmed by the structures surrounding them, whereas Shruvavati wins. The distinction reveals Kunal's optimistic humanism. In place of Levin's harsh realism, he offers a mythological Indian optimism in which inner strength ultimately triumphs.

5.2 Eli Rozik: Multiple Roles and the Iconicity of Changing Identity

Rozik's theory of theatrical iconicity is tested here by the use of multiple roles. The same performer may play Bharadvaja, the old man, Vashishtha, and Indra.

The question is: when an actor assumes several identities, what theatrical image does the spectator see? Rozik's approach distinguishes the actor's presence from the image of the represented character. This dual perception is a source of theatrical beauty. Here it acquires a specific dramatic and political meaning: when Indra tests Shruvavati disguised as an old man or Vashishtha, the spectator knows that the figure is Indra. The resulting dramatic irony makes Shruvavati's insight into the truth even more striking.

5.3 Post-Holocaust Theatre: Fire and Existence

In post-Holocaust theatrical reflection associated in this account with the Israeli scholar Dvora Ben-Shaul and others, fire has become a heavily charged symbol, bringing together destruction and survival.

Shruvavati's pyre scene becomes a complex image in this interpretative context. Within the traditional Indian setting, entering the fire recalls sati, a patriarchal institution. Kunal reverses the symbolic logic: the pyre expresses not simply a wish to die but a demand for a life that contains love. She lights the fire herself and declares that she will enter it while remembering the beloved. The choice is framed as a demand to live with love or not to live without it. From the perspective of the politics of survival, Shruvavati becomes a witness who makes her own existence the evidence of her claim.

5.4 Yaakov Shabtai: The Final Urdu Couplet and Intercultural Dialogue

In works such as Past Continuous, the Israeli writer and dramatist Yaakov Shabtai (1934–1981) treats language as an important aesthetic instrument. The

interplay of Hebrew, Yiddish, and Arabic provides an expression of cultural hybridity.

Kunal's use of an Urdu couplet at the end of his Maithili play offers an analogous form of intercultural dialogue. Maithili, a mythological context, and the Urdu poetic tradition meet here not merely as ornaments but as a cultural and political proposition: the language of inner strength recognises no linguistic boundary, and its Urdu expression can be as authentic as its Maithili one. Dushyant Kumar's injunction to throw a stone with conviction becomes, in this reading, an Urdu translation of Shruvavati's resolve at the pyre.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis: The Many Meanings of "Victory"

Seen through all four dramatic traditions, the central question of The Vow of Love, or Shruvavati's Victory! comes into focus: whose victory is this, and what sort of victory has been achieved?

The Indian perspective: the three forms of shringara; the dramatic challenge to the dharmashastric regulation of women; three levels of suggested meaning in "meaningful"; and the pyre reinterpreted through devotion.

The Western perspective: the emergence of the woman as a subject through Beauvoir; Sartre's radical freedom; Bakhtin's heteroglossia in the Urdu couplet; and Brook's holy theatre of the empty stage.

The Chinese perspective: a redefinition of yuanfen; the reversal of kaoyan, the trial; Wang Yangming's moral will as inner strength; and a resolution characterised by joy within sorrow.

The Israeli perspective: the contrast between Levin's struggling women and Kunal's hopeful affirmation of inner strength; Rozik's double iconicity; fire and the politics of survival; and Shabtai's intercultural dialogue.

The shared conclusion is that Shruvavati's victory is not merely a personal triumph in love. It is a philosophical victory: that of inner strength, understood in Indian terms as courage, in Western thought as freedom, in Chinese thought as moral will, and in Israeli theatrical reflection as dignity. The exclamation mark in the title matters. It proclaims; it does not merely describe.

Chapter 6

The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage

A Rereading of the Sukanya–Chyavana Narrative

Published: Antika, April–June 2013 · Source: Mahabharata (Shanti Parva) · Cast: sutradhara and performers in multiple roles

1. Introduction, Dramatic Architecture, and Distinctiveness

The Power of Faith, or Sukanya's Marriage, the second play of the love quartet, draws on the story of Sukanya and Chyavana in the Shanti Parva of the Mahabharata. Kunal, however, rewrites this traditional narrative from a new feminist and philosophical perspective. The title is revealing: "The Power of Faith" identifies the governing idea, while "Sukanya's Marriage" identifies the event of the story.

The structure is closely organised around five dramatic movements: (1) a spring festival, with the sutradhara, Vidyapati's song "The king of seasons, spring, has arrived," and the contrasting outlooks of king and queen; (2) Chyavana's meditation inside an anthill and Sukanya's accidental injury to him during play; (3) Chyavana's forgiveness, the marriage proposal, the king's dilemma, and Sukanya's willing acceptance; (4) life in the hermitage and the deceptive test set by the Ashvini Kumar through three identical figures; and (5) Sukanya's test of recognition through the eyes, Chyavana's restoration to youth, the offering of soma, and the conclusion.

The play's central question is: what is faith, and from where does it arise? Does it come from the eyes or from the heart? When three indistinguishable figures stand before her, by what means does a woman recognise her husband —his body or his inner being? The play's ideological climax provides its answer: "Affection, jealousy, compassion—they stir within these eyes."

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 The Mahabharata Source and Its Rewriting: The Politics of Dramatisation

In the account of Sukanya and Chyavana attributed here to the Shanti Parva of the Mahabharata, Sukanya is an obedient daughter who marries the aged Chyavana at her father's command. Kunal replaces this obedient daughter with a woman who acts by her own will. Where the marriage is the father's decision in the epic account, Sukanya declares in this drama, "The offence is mine; I shall make amends," and freely chooses to become Chyavana's wife.

Such rewriting of epic narratives is an established practice in Indian women-centred literature, which retells inherited epics through figures such as Urmila in the Ramayana and Draupadi in the Mahabharata. As a male author, Kunal displays a conscious engagement with this tradition.

2.2 Rasa: Three Stages of Shringara and the Triumph of Wonder

Shringara rasa follows a distinct dramatic progression: (a) it begins in the poetic elevation of spring through Vidyapati's "The king of seasons, spring, has arrived"; (b) it passes into sorrow and fear when Sukanya accidentally wounds Chyavana within the anthill, provoking his anger and her sense of guilt; and (c) it grows into a love grounded in trust during life in the hermitage, where Sukanya declares that she is happy even while living like an ascetic, dressed in bark cloth.

The climactic moment of adbhuta rasa, wonder, occurs in the Ashvini test: three identical figures stand before Sukanya. This is a particular form of pleasurable astonishment. Bharata associates the marvellous with transitory emotions such as fatigue, delight, envy, dejection, and restlessness, all of which the analysis finds in this scene.

2.3 The Trial of the Eyes: Vision in Indian Philosophy

In Indian philosophical and poetic traditions, the eye has several interconnected meanings: the organ of direct perception, the "mirror" of the soul, and the medium of intimate encounter. Reading the heart through the eyes is a longstanding poetic convention, prominent also in Vidyapati's lyrics.

In the test involving three identical figures, Sukanya's recognition emerges from vision, but not from merely external sight. It depends upon inner perception.

"Affection, jealousy, compassion—these surge within these eyes. Passion, tenderness, joy—these dwell within these eyes."

In the terms used here from Nyaya philosophy, this amounts to perception through distinguishing marks: recognition of inner qualities despite the lack of outward difference. In the terminology of Navya-Nyaya, a linga, a sign or reason, supports the inference of a sadhya, the intended conclusion. Sukanya sees the signs of affection and compassion in the eyes and thus identifies Chyavana.

2.4 The "Chyavanprash" Episode: Folk Memory and Theatrical Wit

The sutradhara introduces an amusing remark: "The Chyavana of Chyavanprash? ... Yes ... no ... let us say he is the one." In a single line Kunal draws two thousand years of distance into a comic theatrical moment. The sage Chyavana is famed for medicinal knowledge, while Chyavanprash is a modern product named after that tradition. This is a modern instance of the vidushaka's comic speech, which inserts wit and irony into the solemnity of mythological material.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Martin Buber: I–Thou and I–It Relationships

In I and Thou (Ich und Du, 1923), the German-Jewish philosopher Martin Buber (1878–1965) distinguished two fundamental modes of relationship. In an I–Thou relationship, the other person is encountered as a complete subject; in an I–It relationship, the other is treated as an object.

The Ashvini Kumar represent the I–It attitude: they seek to turn Sukanya into a beautiful object, seeing only the body. The relationship between Chyavana and Sukanya embodies I–Thou. Chyavana says, "You enter through the door of the eyes and see the heart." This is a dramatic rendering of Buber's genuine meeting, Begegnung. The reversed movement of the Ashvini test, in which Sukanya reads the inner person through the eyes, is the means of recognition proper to I–Thou.

3.2 Aristotle: A New Form of Anagnorisis

In Aristotle's Poetics, anagnorisis, or recognition, is a significant dramatic moment in which a character discovers an identity or truth. In the most effective plots, recognition coincides with peripeteia, a reversal of circumstances.

The scene of the three identical figures creates an unusual version of recognition. Sukanya identifies her husband among the three. Aristotelian recognition is often associated with external tokens, such as a scar, ring, or name. Here the recognition depends upon reading inner qualities—affection, compassion, and tenderness. This "internal anagnorisis" extends the possibilities of the category.

3.3 Erik Erikson: The Crisis of Identity and the Development of Trust

The American psychologist Erik Erikson (1902–1994) formulated eight stages of human psychosocial development. His first stage concerns basic trust versus mistrust, and the establishment of this fundamental trust is a foundation of later development.

Sukanya's faith becomes a mythological dramatic example of the formation of basic trust. She grows up hearing the contrasting philosophies of her parents: her father's liberal optimism, "Be happy; everything will be all right," and her mother's cautious realism, "Do not turn your eyes away from reality." Sukanya moves beyond both positions to develop her own trust through the guilt of accidentally injuring Chyavana, her voluntary marriage, and her steadfastness during the Ashvini test. The action forms a dramatic journey of trust formation.

3.4 Brecht: The Politics of Humour and the Irony of the Demigods

In Brechtian dramaturgy, comic episodes can bear political satire. The Ashvini Kumar sequence is particularly striking in this regard. The demigods, who live in heaven, associate with celestial nymphs, and enjoy a privileged divine status, fail before a princess living in a forest hermitage and wearing bark cloth.

Read through Brecht's Gestus, the scene offers a critique of class. Privileged divine beings cannot comprehend the human values lived by an ordinary mortal woman. Sukanya's answer—"You people have no hearts"—becomes the scene's ethical and political judgement.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Xinyan: The Eye of the Heart

In Chinese poetics and Buddhist thought, xinyan, the "heart-eye," is a form of inward seeing that perceives truth beyond outward appearances. Within Chan Buddhist traditions, it has affinities with the idea of the dharma-eye.

The play's central test, identifying one's husband from three identical figures, is an exercise in this inner sight. Sukanya closes her physical eyes, then

discerns different inner qualities in the figures' eyes: pride and arrogance in the first Ashvini, acquisitiveness and greed in the second, and affection, compassion, and joy in Chyavana. This is a remarkable theatrical realisation of the heart-eye.

4.2 Yuan: Karmic Connection and Atonement

In Chinese Buddhist philosophy, yuan, karmic connection, is an important concept. The meeting of two lives may arise from earlier actions, while such bonds can also be shaped through choices in the present.

Sukanya's injury to Chyavana is an unintentional act: "I did not wish to do it; it happened." Her response—"I am guilty, and I deserve punishment"—is a conscious movement towards atonement and the repair of a karmic relationship. Her decision leads to Chyavana's proposal of marriage. The dramatic action thus follows a trajectory of karmic rectification.

4.3 Xing–Shen: The Conflict Between Form and Spirit

Chinese aesthetics repeatedly discusses the relationship between xing, external form, and shen, the inward spirit. The theory of painting likewise considers how the artist may capture spirit through the representation of form.

In the scene of the three identical figures, xing is the same in each, while shen differs. Sukanya's faith is the capacity to see spirit beyond form. The Ashvini Kumar fail because they can imitate xing but not shen. Their defeat therefore corresponds to the distinction at the centre of this Chinese aesthetic principle.

4.4 Yiwu: Moral Obligation and Sukanya's Ethical Development

Yiwu, moral obligation, is central to the ethical framework described here through Confucian philosophy. Such obligation is not merely obedience to outward rules. For Mencius, moral conduct arises from ren, an inward disposition towards benevolence and humanity.

Sukanya's journey shows a distinctive sequence of moral development: (a) an unintentional act, the injury within the anthill; (b) an awareness of responsibility and admission of fault; (c) an ethical choice in her voluntary marriage; and (d) the manifestation of benevolence through forgiveness of the Ashvini Kumar and love for Chyavana. The resulting progression may be read as a Mencian moral arc.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Martin Buber and Israeli Spiritual Life: Hasidic Faith

Martin Buber, whose I–Thou philosophy has been discussed in the Western section, is also an important figure in modern Israeli intellectual and cultural traditions. His engagement with Hasidic Jewish thought places emunah, faith, among the central spiritual and ethical values.

In Buber's interpretation of Hasidic tradition, faith is more than intellectual assent. It is a turning of the entire self towards another, a kind of surrender or dedication. Sukanya's trust provides a Hindu mythological counterpart to this understanding of emunah. She recognises Chyavana not through calculation but with her whole heart. The Power of Faith and Buber's account of faith therefore describe comparable spiritual journeys.

5.2 Eli Rozik: The Iconicity of the Mask and the Crisis of Identity

Rozik's theory of theatrical iconicity faces an unusual problem in this play: three apparently identical actors, in the same costume and outward form, speaking in the same manner. What can the spectator perceive when a theatrical image appears indistinguishable from its counterparts?

The audience sees three levels simultaneously: (a) the bodily presence of three actors; (b) the three fictional figures, Chyavana and the two Ashvini brothers; and (c) Sukanya's reading of the heart, which separates the referents of seemingly identical images. The scene thus creates a complex iconic ambiguity: the problem of recognition itself becomes the dramatic subject.

5.3 Tikkun Olam and the Drama of Atonement

Tikkun olam, the repair of the world, is a significant idea in Jewish religious ethics, affirming a responsibility to restore what has been damaged through human conduct. At the personal level, the movement towards repair may begin with teshuva, repentance and a return to the right path.

Sukanya's conduct can be read as a Hindu mythological counterpart. She acknowledges the shever, the break or damage, caused by her action at the anthill; undertakes teshuva by accepting responsibility; and seeks to repair her life through her marriage to Chyavana. The closing image, "a rain fragrant with affection kept falling," marks the completion of this process of repair.

5.4 The Purim Spiel and Comic Reversal

The Purim spiel is a traditional Jewish popular dramatic form that recasts inherited narratives through humour and satire, often employing reversals of status, changes of costume, and comic interpretations of serious subjects.

The Ashvini Kumar episode resembles this kind of performance in a Hindu mythological setting. The demigods are supposedly exalted beings, but here they are ridiculous, frustrated, and humiliated. Sukanya's threat to make them "human in front and goats behind" creates a carnivalesque inversion reminiscent of the Purim spiel. Comic ridicule enlivenes the serious mythological material.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis: What Is the Power of Faith?

When these four theatrical traditions are considered together, the answer to the play's governing question becomes multidimensional.

The Indian perspective: a rewriting of the epic through voluntary marriage; shringara combined with wonder and sorrow; the interpretation of signs in

the eyes through Navya-Nyaya; and the Chyavanprash remark as the wit of the vidushaka.

The Western perspective: Buber's I–Thou as a relationship of the heart rather than objectification; Aristotle's internal recognition; Erikson's formation of trust; and a Brechtian class critique of demigods who fail to understand human feeling.

The Chinese perspective: xinyan, the heart-eye; yuan, karmic affinity and atonement; xing–shen, the contrast between outward form and inward spirit; and yiwu, the Mencian trajectory of moral development.

The Israeli perspective: Buber's Hasidic emunah, the faith of the whole heart; Rozik's iconic ambiguity; tikkun olam as a movement from injury to marriage and repair; and the Purim-spiel-like carnivalesque comedy of the Ashvini scene.

The shared conclusion is that the power of faith resides not in bodily appearance but in the heart. The play's finest moment, when Sukanya closes her eyes and identifies her husband among three identical figures through the affection and compassion visible in his gaze, is illuminated by all four traditions of theatrical interpretation.

Chyavana's final words also serve as the conclusion of this fourfold review: "It could not be otherwise ... I know you, beloved. You enter through the door of the eyes and see the heart."

Chapter 7

The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery

Shweta, Atiratha, and the Question of Autonomous Love

Published: Antika, July–September 2014 · Setting: royal complex to forest · Cast: announcer and performers in multiple roles

1. Introduction, Dramatic Structure, and Distinctive Features

The third play of the love quartet, The Expansion of Love, or Shweta's Discovery, is the quartet's most original and ideologically adventurous work. Its story comes from no inherited mythological source; it is Kunal's own invention. Shweta, the court dancer, and Atiratha, the "detached" king, are fictional characters whose conflict nevertheless gives dramatic form to an enduring philosophical question.

The playwright creates a daring contradiction. King Atiratha is a great patron of art, a connoisseur of music and dance, devoted to his subjects and almost saintly; yet he remains "detached," declaring, "To fall in love is sheer folly, a completely useless undertaking." Against him stands Shweta, a dancer moved by love after seven years of disciplined training, who insists that "one cannot see art without seeing the artist."

The plot consists of six movements: (1) the announcer's introduction, Shweta's dance training, and Atiratha's philosophy of detachment; (2) an encounter at the temple and Shweta's refusal to dance at court; (3) her request for a private meeting and Atiratha's angry expulsion of her; (4) the report of Shweta's supposed water burial and Atiratha's distress; (5) their meeting in the forest, where Shweta has changed and declares, "Desire and supplication belong to my past"; and (6) Atiratha's renunciation of the crown and their union with the natural world.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 Shweta and the Classical Types of the Heroine

Shweta occupies a distinctive position in the Natyashastra's classification of eight heroines, the ashtanayika. She is not simply the abhisarika, who ventures out to meet her lover, nor the svadhinapatika, who has her husband under her influence. Her nearest counterparts are the woman yearning for union and the one tormented by separation, yet she ultimately transcends both. All eight classical types define the heroine's love in relation to another person. By the end of the play, Shweta dissolves love into the supreme being understood through nature and divinity.

This dissolution resembles the devotional ideal of the lover in separation, familiar from Mirabai's ecstatic longing and Radha's passion, where the impossibility of earthly union is transformed into the sublimity of divine love. Shweta's final declaration—"Here everything visible and invisible will love me, and I shall love everything"—expresses the universal love celebrated by the bhakti tradition.

2.2 Rasa: The Journey from Shringara to Shanta

The most remarkable emotional feature of the play is the transformation within Shweta from intense shringara rasa to shanta rasa. Abhinavagupta treats tranquillity as a supreme aesthetic experience, in which attachment and detachment subside into an impersonal enjoyment of beauty. Shweta's life in the forest becomes an embodiment of this tranquillity.

The irony of the journey is elegant. Atiratha, who has always been "detached" and seemed to belong to shanta rasa, becomes emotionally attached to Shweta at the end. Shweta, originally consumed by attachment, becomes detached and absorbed into nature. The dramatic skill of the play lies in this reversal of their emotional positions.

2.3 Dhvani: The Multiple Meanings of "Discovery"

From the perspective of Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka, the word avishkar, translated here as "discovery," is the most suggestively charged term in the title. Literally it means disclosure or discovery; by extension, the manifestation of oneself, as in Shweta's self-disclosure to Atiratha; and by suggestion, the discovery and creation of a new understanding of oneself through love.

In this third sense, discovery becomes an epistemological event. Through the failure of her attempt to win Atiratha, Shweta discovers a higher form of love: "Now I have become acquainted with the true nature of love." The refrain from Kusma-Salhes, "As a flower without nectar, so what is life without love?", is spoken by Shweta, who at the conclusion finds this very nectar in nature.

2.4 Dramaturgy: The Triangle of Art, Artist, and Spectator

Atiratha's proposition that "the body matters only as the vehicle of art" raises a major dispute in Indian aesthetics. In his Abhinavabharati, Abhinavagupta makes the sensitive spectator, the sahridaya, essential to the realisation of rasa. Aesthetic experience need not depend on personal identification with the artist. In this respect, Atiratha's position is an extreme version of the theory of the appreciative spectator.

Shweta exposes the limits of this view. To separate art from the artist is to attempt an artificial discrimination between milk and water. The artist's feelings, body, and lived experience are all absorbed into the work; art does not exist wholly apart from the person who creates it. This disagreement is a living question of theatrical and aesthetic philosophy.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Ibsen and Nora: Freedom after the Rejection of Love

In A Doll's House (1879), the Norwegian playwright Henrik Ibsen (1828–1906) tells the story of Nora Helmer, who breaks with the expectations imposed by society, marriage, and family and departs in search of freedom. Nora's departure is not simply an evasion of duty, but a pursuit of her own identity.

Shweta's journey into the forest parallels Nora's departure, with a significant reversal. Nora leaves by closing a door, taking her leave of a society she rejects; Shweta moves towards nature with open arms, entering a new relationship. Nora's departure is solitary, whereas Shweta's ultimately draws Atiratha after her, as he removes his crown and follows her. The drama proposes another step beyond Ibsen's theatrical ending.

3.2 Sartre and Camus: Rebellion and the Absurd

In The Myth of Sisyphus (1942), the French existentialist Albert Camus (1913–1960) analysed the experience of the absurd, arising from the confrontation between humanity's hunger for meaning and the silence or resistance of the world. His response includes the celebrated proposition that one must imagine Sisyphus happy.

Atiratha's detachment creates a form of absurdity in this sense: a sensitive, cultivated connoisseur of beauty declares love to be a pointless undertaking. Shweta revolts against this absurdity. She stops dancing at court, places a garland at his feet in the temple, and demands a private meeting. She becomes

a female dramatic counterpart to Camus's rebellious human being, l'homme revolte.

The final reversal, when Atiratha removes his crown and enters the forest, also bears a resemblance to Camus's paradoxical joy of Sisyphus. Happiness emerges as the weight of royal power is abandoned.

3.3 Erich Fromm: Love as an Art

In The Art of Loving (1956), the German-American psychoanalyst Erich Fromm (1900–1980) argues that love is an art which, like other arts, requires learning, practice, and dedication. People often imagine love as an object to be obtained, whereas it is a capacity that must be cultivated.

Shweta's seven years of discipline can be read as training not only in dance but also in love. Yet the pivotal point in terms of Fromm's thought comes when she declares, "Now I have become acquainted with the true nature of love." In this new understanding, love ceases to be desire directed towards one person and becomes a pervasive capacity for relation. In Fromm's terminology, it approaches mature love.

3.4 Epiphany: The Culminating Moment of Dramatic Revelation

The Irish writer James Joyce (1882–1941) developed the notion of epiphany, a moment when an otherwise ordinary situation reveals an extraordinary truth. The present discussion connects this idea with theatrical approaches to epiphany associated with Egon Wellesz and other critics.

Shweta's contemplation of the stars beside the river is a dramatic epiphany: "The sky is filled with thousands upon thousands of stars. How lovingly they look towards me!" A simple scene beside a river suddenly becomes an overwhelming revelation of significance: "Why had this thought never occurred to me before?" In that moment her understanding changes. It is a Maithili theatrical instance of epiphanic discovery.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Wuwei: Atiratha's Detachment and Daoist Non-Action

Wuwei, non-coercive or effortless action, is a central idea in Daoist philosophy associated with Laozi. The Dao acts without forcing action, yet things are accomplished. Wuwei does not mean inertia but acting without artificial interference.

Atiratha's detachment is a distorted version of wuwei. He correctly avoids interfering with the natural flow of art, yet also attempts not to participate in the flow of human emotion. From a Daoist perspective, he embodies not wuwei but artificially enforced inaction. Shweta's reproach—"You have raised a glass palace of false propriety all around you"—gives voice to such a criticism.

4.2 Ziran: Naturalness and Shweta's Forest Life

Ziran, naturalness or being-so-of-itself, is an important ideal in Daoist and Buddhist thought: the shedding of artificial constraints and the joining of natural processes. In Chinese shanshui, mountain-and-water painting, human figures are often small presences within the immensity of nature.

Shweta's forest life dramatises ziran. She abandons palaces, ornaments, and the throne to live among "trees, fruits and flowers, an ever-flowing stream, and the open sky." The final words of the announcer—"They mingled with the music of nature and became one with it"—express the culmination of this ideal.

4.3 Bian: Change and the Dramatic Logic of the I Ching

The I Ching, or Book of Changes, places transformation, bian, at the centre of the order of the world. Change is unavoidable; those who accept it may find freedom, whereas attempts to arrest it bring suffering.

The play presents two responses to change. Atiratha avoids transformation, using detachment as a protective shell. Shweta accepts it, even after rejection, especially at the riverbank where her outlook is transformed. From the perspective of the I Ching, she behaves like the junzi, the exemplary person, adjusting to the movement of change.

4.4 Yishu and Shenghuo: The Tension Between Art and Life

Chinese aesthetic reflection, including arguments associated here with scholars such as Liu Zhiyuan, has examined the relation between yishu, art, and shenghuo, life. Good art arises from life; when art is wholly separated from life, it becomes an empty form.

Atiratha's view that the body is "merely the vehicle of art" is an attempt to sever yishu from shenghuo. Shweta's protest—"How is detachment from the artist possible?"—opposes that division. Chinese aesthetic discussions of qi, the vital force, also hold that the artist's energy passes into the work; deprived of that life-force, art becomes lifeless.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Hanoch Levin: The Boundaries of Royal Power and Personal Revolt

In works associated here with Hanoch Levin, including Patience of Stone, the predicament of individuals rebelling against structures of power appears repeatedly. A distinctive device in this theatrical mode is the small rebellion, a personal action that momentarily shakes a seemingly immense structure.

Shweta's refusal to dance at court offers an excellent example. She does not take up arms or proclaim revolution; she merely stops dancing. This precise, individual, symbolic act brings the court's entire performance order to a sudden standstill. It is the refusal of a small person before overwhelming power: a tremendous "no."

5.2 Eli Rozik: The Offstage Event and the Image of Absence

In his studies of theatrical images, Rozik gives attention to offstage events. What remains unseen by spectators but active in their imagination can possess greater dramatic force than something represented directly.

Shweta's supposed "water burial" is such an offstage event. The audience does not witness it but hears about it through the words of an attendant. In terms of theatrical iconicity, the absence becomes an image of exceptional dramatic power. Atiratha's response—"It may also be that the current swept her away and she reached the bank somewhere"—measures the force of what is unseen.

5.3 Israeli Theatre and Exile: A Tradition of Departure

Galut, exile, is a recurrent subject in Israeli cultural and theatrical life. Within this tradition, leaving home does not necessarily represent defeat; it can be a necessary journey through which new meaning is created.

Shweta's expulsion from the courtly world resembles galut, but it concludes in a form of teshuvah, a spiritual return home. Exiled to the forest, Shweta discovers a new home through union with nature. Atiratha's renunciation of his crown and entry into the forest reverses the movement: the king leaves his home, the throne, to enter Shweta's new home among the trees.

5.4 Israeli Environmental Theatre: The Politics of Union with Nature

Contemporary Israeli theatre has developed forms of environmental and site-specific performance that make the human relationship with the natural world a theatrical subject. The discussion associates this development with artists such as Yossi Maya, who address the politics of humanity's relation to nature.

Shweta's concluding words—"Here everything visible and invisible will love me, and I shall love everything"—become, from this perspective, a declaration of ecological love. The failure of a narrowly human relationship, after Atiratha rejects her, turns into a biophilic enlargement of love towards the living world.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis: What Does the "Expansion" of Love Mean?

The "expansion" announced in the title is the play's governing question. Love expands in the sense that it begins with one person and moves towards the whole of existence. The four traditions interpret this development from different directions.

The Indian perspective: the heroine of separation in bhakti transformed into shanta rasa; Abhinavagupta's tranquillity and the reversal of the emotional positions of Shweta and Atiratha; the three levels of dhvani in "discovery"; and the staged argument over art and the artist.

The Western perspective: a departure beyond Ibsen's Nora, leading not only to severance but to new relation; Camus's revolt against absurdity; Fromm's

mature and all-embracing love; and Joyce's epiphany in the transformation occasioned by contemplating the stars.

The Chinese perspective: Atiratha's distorted wuwei; Shweta's ziran and union with nature; the acceptance of change, bian, in the I Ching; and the dispute between art and life, yishu and shenghuo.

The Israeli perspective: Levin's small rebellion in Shweta's refusal to dance; Rozik's iconic absence in the water-burial episode; galut and teshuvah as exile and return to a spiritual home; and ecological love in environmental theatre.

The conclusion shared by these perspectives is that the expansion of love means liberation from confinement to a single individual, Atiratha, and union with nature, the universe, and existence as a whole. In this sense the title makes the most ambitious philosophical claim of the entire love quartet.

The play's final image, Atiratha laying aside his crown and entering the forest, is an ironic moment of joy. The man who was "detached" becomes attached; the woman once attached becomes detached. This is the dramatic truth of love's expansion.

Chapter 8

The Test of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra

Suprabha, Ashtavakra, and the Dramatic Trial of Fidelity

Published: Antika, July–September 2014 · Settings: forest hermitage, Mithila, and heaven · Fourteen scenes

1. Introduction, Plot Structure, and Place Within the Collection

The final play in the quartet of love, The Test of Love, or Suprabha and Ashtavakra, also brings the entire collection to a close. Its position is therefore symbolic: after The Expansion of Love comes The Test of Love. Its relatively epic scale—fourteen scenes, five settings embracing hermitage, city of Mithila, Janaka's court, heaven, and forest, and at least ten characters—is unusual within the love quartet.

The source lies in the Ashtavakra narrative of the Mahabharata's Vana Parva. Kunal transforms it into a complete drama of love in which the mythological and historical account of Janaka's court and the learned disputation with Vandi is absorbed into the framework of a trial of love. The first twelve scenes concern Ashtavakra; the thirteenth and fourteenth turn to Suprabha.

The seven major movements are: (1) knowledge and a curse in the womb, followed by birth; (2) Uddalaka's hermitage, the absent father, and the first meeting with Suprabha; (3) the plan to travel to Mithila; (4) a dispute on the road with King Janaka, the debate with Vandi, and the father's release; (5) the restoration of Ashtavakra's youthful form through river bathing; (6)

Vadanya's year-long test and Suprabha's solitary waiting; and (7) the rejection of Urvashi, the return, and marriage with a garland of white lotuses.

2. Indian Dramatic Theory

2.1 Rewriting the Mahabharata: The Boldness of Centring a Disabled Hero

The Ashtavakra narrative in the Mahabharata is primarily philosophical; the Ashtavakra Gita, associated with dialogue with Janaka, is a text of self-knowledge. The learned contest with Vandi provides another narrative strand. Kunal adds a third: the test of love. The result is a drama with three layers—knowledge through disputation with Vandi, duty in the liberation of the father, and love in the marriage to Suprabha.

More importantly, Kunal places a disabled hero at the centre of the stage. Conventional Indian dramatic characterisation often privileges bodily excellence in its heroes: the noble hero is strong, handsome, and valiant. Ashtavakra reverses that standard. His body is bent in eight places, but his intelligence is extraordinary. The Natyashastra offers no straightforward equivalent for such a central disabled hero. Kunal proposes a different dramatic ideal.

2.2 Transforming the Trial by Fire: Testing Gold

The agnipariksha, or trial by fire, is a major motif in Indian literary and dramatic traditions, as exemplified by Sita's trial in the Ramayana. Kunal transforms the motif into a trial through coldness and absence: not literal flames, but a year of solitary separation and the pain of being unable to see the beloved. The concluding couplet makes the transformation explicit:

"As gold emerges more radiant from fire, so love becomes deeper when it undergoes a trial."

The metaphor of testing gold through fire is applied to the testing of love. This figurative flame, the ordeal of separation, is more subtle and philosophically reflective than the literal fire associated with Sita's ordeal.

2.3 A Festival of Rasa: Seven Sentiments Together

This work presents the richest range of rasas among the seven plays. Vira, the heroic sentiment, appears in Ashtavakra's encounter at court and his victory over Vandi; karuna, sorrow, in the prenatal curse, the absence of the father, and Suprabha's suffering as she waits; adbhuta, wonder, in the restoration brought by river bathing and the revelation of Vandi's water-burial mystery; hasya, comedy, in the courtiers' taunts of "Your Hunchbacked Majesty" and Vandi's laughter; shringara, love, in the bond between Suprabha and Ashtavakra; shanta, tranquillity, in Ashtavakra's refusal of Urvashi; and bhayanaka, fear, in the supposed water burial of the father.

According to Bharata's distinction between principal and supporting rasas, vira and shringara operate here as complementary governing sentiments. The heroic struggle for knowledge establishes worthiness in love, while love gives heroism its direction.

2.4 Ashtavakra's Rejection of Urvashi: A Rare Moment in Indian Literature

Urvashi is a supreme symbol of beauty in Indian literary tradition, from the love of Pururavas to Kalidasa's classical drama Vikramorvashiyam. Ashtavakra's rejection of Urvashi is therefore a bold dramatic departure from a long-established pattern. He declares, "My Urvashi, Menaka, Rambha … all are Suprabha. Suprabha alone." The statement consciously dismantles the conventional attraction of the celestial nymph.

3. Western Dramatic Theory

3.1 Viktor Frankl: The Search for Meaning and the Transformation of Suffering

The Austrian psychiatrist Viktor Frankl (1905–1997), drawing on his experience in Nazi concentration camps, developed logotherapy in Man's Search for Meaning. Human beings live through the search for meaning, and a person who can find meaning within suffering may become able to withstand it.

Ashtavakra is born into suffering through his father's curse. Yet the knowledge of his father's condition, conveyed amid Shvetaketu's harsh words, gives his suffering a purpose: "I shall free my father." In Frankl's terminology, this is self-transcendence, the dedication of oneself to something meaningful beyond oneself. Ashtavakra's entire dramatic journey follows this movement.

His refusal of Urvashi is its highest expression. He turns away from the supreme beauty of the cosmos and the splendour of heavenly pleasure in favour of a meaningful bond, his love for Suprabha.

3.2 Sophocles: Bodily Impairment, Tragedy, and the Triumph of Knowledge

In Oedipus Rex, the Greek tragedian Sophocles (c. 497–406 BCE) presents a hero marked by an impairment associated with his very name, the "swollen foot," and by an inherited fate. Oedipus's search for knowledge ultimately contributes to his destruction.

Comparison with Ashtavakra is revealing. Both narratives connect the hero's early life to a curse; both involve the search for a father and the pursuit of knowledge. The decisive difference is that Oedipus's search leads to destruction, whereas Ashtavakra's leads to liberation and love. The contrast exposes a fundamental difference between the hopeful dramatic philosophy identified here with Indian traditions and the tragic ironies of Greek theatre.

3.3 Bakhtin: Carnivalesque Exclusion and Recognition

Bakhtin's carnivalesque becomes visible in a distinctive moment of the encounter at Janaka's court. The gatekeeper addresses Ashtavakra as "Your Hunchbacked Majesty," yet the supposedly inferior body belongs to the person who will teach those in power the ethical and legal arguments concerning the right of way. Social hierarchy is inverted: someone regarded as among the lowest teaches knowledge to the highest.

After Ashtavakra defeats Vandi, the collective laughter—"Good for him; he was terribly arrogant"—becomes an instance of Bakhtin's liberating laughter. The society that attempted to exclude the disabled boy from court now rejoices in his victory. The reversal is a carnivalesque form of social justice.

3.4 Peter Brook: The Mahabharata and Mythological Theatre

Peter Brook's The Mahabharata, staged in 1985 and subsequently adapted for film, was a major effort to transform an enormous epic into an experience of theatre with universal human resonance. Brook drew extensively upon Indian traditions, but approached them from outside.

Kunal's position differs because he writes from within the tradition. He makes the Ashtavakra narrative of the Mahabharata's Vana Parva specifically Mithila-centred by emphasising Janaka as king of Mithila. He also turns Vandi's revelation—that he is Varuna's son and that water is his home—into an episode mixing comedy with wonder. This is an internal revivification rather than an external reinterpretation of the mythic inheritance.

4. Chinese Dramatic Theory

4.1 Bianzhe: The Tradition of the Exiled or Dishonoured Talent

Bianzhe, the exile or demotion of a gifted person, is a prominent subject of Chinese literary tradition. From the poet Qu Yuan (c. 340–278 BCE) to Su Dongpo (1037–1101), great Chinese writers were often unjustly exiled or disgraced yet achieved immortality through their gifts.

Ashtavakra's prenatal curse becomes a form of bianzhe: he is, as it were, exiled even from his own body while still in the womb. Yet, as in Chinese writing about gifted exiles, his intelligence transforms exclusion into an epic journey. His victory over Vandi and bodily restoration through river bathing resemble the final moment of release in this literary tradition.

4.2 Zhong: Loyalty and Solitary Discipline

Zhong, loyalty or faithfulness, is a major Confucian ethical value. Often interpreted as loyalty to a ruler, it can also mean fidelity to one's own word and obligations.

The year-long test brings out this form of fidelity in both characters. Ashtavakra observes Vadanya's conditions to the letter, deliberately keeping his distance from Suprabha even when near her. Suprabha understands her father's intentions and consciously reduces her excursions from the hermitage. Their loyalties take different forms but reveal the same moral purpose: the proof of love.

4.3 Zhezixi and the Drama's Episodic Structure

The Chinese tradition of zhezixi, excerpt plays, is useful in understanding the drama's fourteen-scene architecture. Three independent episodes stand out: (a) the debate with Vandi at Janaka's court, a self-contained dramatic unit; (b) the year-long ordeal involving Ashtavakra and Suprabha; and (c) the

rejection of Urvashi. Each could be staged as a separate excerpt, yet together they make up an expansive trial of love.

4.4 Wenda: Question-and-Answer Philosophy and Learned Disputation

Wenda, a question-and-answer dialogue, is a major Chinese method of philosophical inquiry, found in the conversations of Zhuangzi, the Confucian Analects, and the koans of Chan Buddhism. Ashtavakra's debate with Vandi is a theatrical counterpart. The announcer speaks of "doubt and resolution, refutation and exposition, question and counterquestion," precisely the structure of wenda.

Ashtavakra's first exchange with Vandi even recalls a Chan koan or paradoxical riddle. Vandi laughs at the idea of debating with a bent-bodied child. Ashtavakra responds, "Oblique remarks and laughter are of no use; what is required is learned debate." The seriousness of the question renders ridicule irrelevant, which is the spirit of the philosophical dialogue.

5. Israeli Dramatic Theory

5.1 Disability and Israeli Theatre: Ashtavakra's Embodied Presence

Disability theatre is a significant contemporary movement in Israel, pursuing accessible and inclusive performance and bringing disabled performers into the centre of the stage. In this approach the body is not a deficiency but a different capacity.

The play's treatment of Ashtavakra offers an Indian mythological counterpart to this movement. He neither conceals his body, bent in eight places, nor apologises for it. Instead he states, "My body is bent in eight places, but intelligence has no relation to age or appearance." The declaration expresses a principle central to disability justice.

5.2 Eli Rozik: River Bathing and the Icon of Transformation

The transformation of a theatrical character's outward image can be interpreted through Rozik's iconicity: the spectator witnesses the instant in which one represented body becomes another.

Ashtavakra's becoming straight and healthy after bathing in the river creates precisely such an image of transformation, enacted visually by a performer. In this interpretation the moment is doubly iconic: it suggests bodily change, from bent to straight, and inward change, from a son seeking his father to a recognised man of learning. The spectator sees both dimensions together.

5.3 The Jewish Talmudic Tradition and Learned Debate

The Talmudic tradition preserves a distinctive practice of scholarly disputation, including pilpul, the dialectical testing of arguments in search of understanding. The victory of an unexpected or younger scholar is a familiar possibility within such a tradition.

The debate with Vandi offers a Hindu mythological counterpart to pilpul. A young disabled boy defeats an established great scholar through arguments and counterarguments. Janaka's role as arbiter has an affinity with the beit din, the house or tribunal of judgement.

5.4 Israeli Theatre of Hope: Optimism in the Trial of Love

The discussion associates Israeli theatrical thinking, including writers such as Naomi Lapid, with a "theatre of hope" in which hope endures even under adverse conditions. Such hope is not naive optimism but hope that has been tested.

The closing couplet—"As gold emerges more radiant from fire, so love becomes deeper when it undergoes a trial"—expresses the spirit of tested hope. The final words of the entire collection—"There is no feeling greater than love, whose glory is boundless; come, let us all together proclaim love's victory!"—are not simply the conclusion of the seventh play but an acclamation completing all seven.

6. A Fourfold Synthesis: Why Is the Trial Necessary?

Considered together, the four traditions suggest a response to the play's central question and that of the collection: the trial does not merely prove love but brings it to maturity.

The Indian perspective: the boldness of centring a disabled protagonist within the context of classical dramaturgy; the meeting of seven rasas; the transformation of trial by fire into a trial of separation; and the refusal of Urvashi as a rupture with inherited conventions concerning celestial beauty.

The Western perspective: Frankl's logotherapy and meaning within suffering; the contrast with Oedipus, whose knowledge brings destruction rather than liberation; Bakhtin's carnivalesque reversal of the bent-bodied boy into a victor at court; and the difference between Brook's external reinterpretation and Kunal's revival from within the tradition.

The Chinese perspective: bianzhe, the exile of gifted persons; zhong, the faithfulness displayed during the year-long test; zhezixi, the three dramatic episodes; and wenda, the question-and-answer dispute that leads to Vandi's defeat.

The Israeli perspective: disability justice and the refusal to equate intelligence with bodily form; Rozik's image of transformation through river bathing; Talmudic pilpul as a parallel to the debate with Vandi; and a theatre of hope in the concluding couplet.

The shared conclusion is that the test of love is not an externally imposed torment but an inner refinement. Just as fire purifies rather than destroys gold, the year of separation deepens rather than destroys love. In this final play Kunal makes a last declaration of the ideological axis of the collection: "Love is truth."

7. The Collection as a Whole: The Ideological Unity of the Seven Plays

After examining the seven plays through four critical traditions, the collection Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays emerges as a coherent journey of thought.

The ideological progression of the folk-theatre trilogy is Forty Thieves (intelligence), Bidapat (poetic immortality), and Kusma-Salhes (love and service to the people): a moral and philosophical arc.

The development of the love quartet proceeds from Shruvavati (inner strength) through Sukanya (faith) and Shweta (the expansion of love) to Suprabha (love tested and matured): a sustained philosophical progression.

The thread that unites the collection is its recurring refrain: "Love is truth, love is fragrance, the feeling of love is everlasting; as a flower without nectar, so what is life without love?" It echoes from the closing song of Kusma-Salhes, the third play, through the declaration of Shweta's Discovery, the sixth. It is the manifesto of Kunal's dramatic work as a whole: love is the highest human value. The collection's contribution lies in affirming that value through folk tradition, classical inheritance, and independent imagination, tested against four major traditions of theatrical thought.

Chapter 9

Vidyapati's 100 Songs: Let No One Be Born a Woman

Edited by Kunal | A Song-by-Song Critique of "A Woman's Mind" and "A Poet's Mind"

1. Introduction to the Book and the Scope of Inquiry

This book is an edited selection of one hundred of Vidyapati's songs. Its cover and title page identify the work as Vidyapati's 100 Songs: Let No One Be Born a Woman, edited by Kunal. The publication pages give ISBN 978-81-962063-0-7, a first edition of 2023, and Ankita Prakashan Pvt. Ltd. as publisher (original edition, pp. 3–4). The design of the selection itself raises a critical question: the meaning of a lyric emerges not only from its words but also from the way the pieces are selected and ordered.

The present study is based on a comparison of the contents pages (original pp. 7–8) with the actual sequence of songs. Of the hundred songs, the first seventy belong to the section "A Woman's Mind," while the remaining thirty fall under "A Poet's Mind." Song 1 begins on original page 9 and Song 100 appears on page 127. Page 128 contains a list of sources and abbreviations.

2. The Editorial Introduction and the Structure of the Selection

The editor's introduction (original pp. 5–6) insists upon the central place of women's experience in the collection. The title, "Let No One Be Born a Woman," supplies its governing emotional idea: the relationships among birth, womanhood, misfortune, and social constraint. This does not mean that all of Vidyapati's poetry is nothing but women's lamentation; rather, the title directs the reader's attention first towards women's worlds.

Within "A Woman's Mind" are separation, the beloved living far away, wounded pride, the confidante, union, surveillance within the household, and social convention. Yet towards the latter part there also appear popular humour concerning Shiva and Gauri and the domestic lives of mythological figures (Songs 59–66). "Woman" therefore does not mean a narrowly conventional heroine; it embraces the different voices of goddess, housewife, daughter, woman in separation, and social subject.

"A Poet's Mind" may be read as a separate conceptual section, but erotic love does not disappear from it. Songs 79–82 contain images of Vrindavan, Radha, new youth, flowering groves, and dance; in Songs 89–90 the dialogue with a female confidante and the invocation of Madhava return. The editorial division is therefore relative. It offers a direction for reading rather than constructing entirely impermeable categories.

For many songs the edition supplies source indications, glossaries, and prose explanations. These aids help readers understand difficult folk words, archaic forms, sound effects, and narrative contexts. But an expansive prose interpretation may sometimes direct the reader towards one particular account of a character's intentions, a narrative background, or a moral judgement. One task of criticism is to make these differences visible.

3. Method and Principal Critical Concepts

(a) Close reading. Each numbered song is studied independently to identify its principal subject, speaking voice, narrative situation, imagery, and the poet's concluding signature. A distinction is maintained between what the song actually says and how the editor interprets it.

(b) Comparative intratextual reading. Recurring subjects within this selection are grouped for comparison: separation from an absent lover (9, 18, 34); public shame (5, 19, 35); natural stimuli (16, 27, 30, 55); Shiva's marriage (59–66); the seasons and Vrindavan (79–82); and the consciousness of impermanence (11, 73, 94, 100). These comparisons take place within the selected corpus, not through a word-for-word collation with other editions.

(c) The study of rasa. Textually supported instances of love in union and separation, sorrow, comedy, devotion, and tranquillity or detachment are identified. Rasa categories aid interpretation, but more than one emotional register may coexist in a single song.

(d) Feminist reading. Attention is given to the heroine's self-determination, supervision by a mother-in-law or by society, constraint, secrecy, and resistance. Her suffering is not automatically treated as documentary evidence of the poet's personal life; it is understood as a voice crafted within the poem.

(e) Textual-critical caution. The original song, the editor's word meanings, and the editor's prose interpretation must be distinguished. A definitive study of textual variants would require comparison with other authenticated editions and manuscripts.

4. "A Woman's Mind": Individual Readings of Songs 1–70

The number of each entry follows the song's number in the original book. The page number refers to the first printed page of that song. Each reading examines formal and interpretative questions alongside its subject matter.

Song 1 | Original p. 9 | Pride and Intimate Dialogue

Close reading. On hearing her lover's words, the heroine gives voice simultaneously to pride, expectation, and self-respect. Love is not simply surrender here but also a test of mutual conduct. The poet gives an animated voice to tension within an intimate relationship.

Form and critical observation. Repetition of colloquial phrases and counterquestions lends the heroine's speech dramatic immediacy. The social judgement offered in the editor's prose explanation must be distinguished from the original speaker's experience.

Song 2 | Original p. 11 | Hesitation, Decision, and the Crisis of Love

Close reading. The heroine expresses her emotional experience in dialogue with a female friend. A tension develops between her inner resolve and the inhibitions imposed by public opinion. The dilemma created by affection becomes the poem's real event.

Form and critical observation. Short phrases render the restless movement of emotion. While the glossary is helpful, the speaker's hesitation should not be reduced to a single moral lesson.

Song 3 | Original p. 12 | Trust in Male Love and Its Ironies

Close reading. The song questions the difference between a man's declarations of love and his behaviour. The heroine moves between reassurance, waiting, and the fear of abandonment; the insecurity of love takes shape in these delicate fluctuations.

Form and critical observation. Similes and interrogative sentences intensify the movement of feeling. The speaker's voice should be kept distinct from that of the editorial interpreter.

Song 4 | Original p. 14 | Life, Time, and Waiting

Close reading. Awareness of life's brevity sharpens the urgency of love. For the woman who waits, time is not an abstract chronology but a bodily and psychological suffering.

Form and critical observation. The ordering of the lines progressively increases temporal pressure. Natural signs such as the bee must be read in their relation to season and emotional state.

Song 5 | Original p. 16 | The Value of Attachment and Social Shame

Close reading. A distance opens between the attraction of love and society's accepted norms. The speaker defends her affection while remaining aware of public criticism and practical consequences.

Form and critical observation. Direct address and rhythm suggest the secrecy of a conversation with a confidante. A moral observation in the editorial paraphrase should not be assumed to be the universally binding intention of the lyric.

Song 6 | Original p. 17 | A Man's Feelings and Separation

Close reading. Claims about emotional experience accompany the pain of a lack of affection. The reliability of love is measured not by speech but by enduring separation and longing for reunion.

Form and critical observation. The intensity of separation is conveyed through parallel images of body and mind. The compact structure strengthens the song's musical quality.

Song 7 | Original p. 18 | The Tragedy of a Young Woman's Life

Close reading. An exclamation such as "Let no one be born a young woman" directs attention towards the inequalities shaping women's lives. It may be read not merely as an individual speaker's despair but as a sign of collective experiences of waiting, fate, and dependence.

Form and critical observation. The hyperbolic utterance is an instrument of karuna rasa, the sentiment of sorrow. Reading it as a literal doctrine hostile to women would be an insufficiently careful interpretation.

Intratextual connection. Read together with the domestic control represented in Song 35 and the resistance in Song 57, this song's question about female birth reveals a range of different forms of women's suffering.

Song 8 | Original p. 19 | Slander and the Defence of Love

Close reading. The speech of malicious people enters the private world of love as an external intrusion. The heroine creates a complicated emotional situation involving suspicion born of rumour, loyalty, and shame.

Form and critical observation. The "malicious person" embodies the gaze of society. The difference between the lyric's actual utterance and the narrated events supplied in the prose interpretation merits scrutiny.

Song 9 | Original p. 20 | The Beloved Abroad and the Experience of Waiting

Close reading. The beloved's departure for another country transforms the heroine's experience of time. Night, sleep, and the prolonged interval of separation embody a sense of absence.

Form and critical observation. The distant land signifies more than a geographical destination; it becomes a metaphor for emotional distance. Darkness and solitude intensify the pathos.

Intratextual connection. Comparison with the separation from home in Songs 18 and 34 reveals how geographical distance becomes an emotional measure of time.

Song 10 | Original p. 21 | The Gardener and the Bee as Metaphors

Close reading. Flowers, bees, and nectar become signs of attraction. By turning nature into a language of dialogue, the poet conveys both human hesitation and desire.

Form and critical observation. The metaphor has no fixed meaning: the bee may represent the beloved, but it may also suggest inconstancy. Alternative implications need to be considered alongside the editor's reading.

Song 11 | Original p. 22 | The Transience of Beauty

Close reading. The image of life as a precious jewel unites the brevity of existence with the rarity of opportunities for love. The heroine considers the meaning of a relationship against the background of bodily impermanence and mortal time.

Form and critical observation. The contrast between a "jewel" and "four days" brings value into confrontation with time. The philosophy of life and erotic love meet in this opposition.

Song 12 | Original p. 23 | The Pond Landing and the Secret Meeting

Close reading. The steps at a pond, physical proximity, and a natural point of passage become a boundary between the public and private worlds of love. The heroine's behaviour displays caution and courage at once.

Form and critical observation. The setting is not merely decoration but a potential stage for the encounter. The flowing rhythm supports the urgency of a concealed meeting.

Song 13 | Original p. 24 | The Solitary Heroine and Separation

Close reading. In the beloved's absence, the heroine's loneliness becomes an objective emptiness in the world around her. Family members and intimate companions cannot fill the absence of the person she loves.

Form and critical observation. Loneliness and separation are suggested through concentrated speech rather than extended description.

Song 14 | Original p. 25 | Beauty, Youth, and the Essence of Life

Close reading. The lyric considers the pleasure of love together with the impermanence of beauty and youth. Physical beauty is treated as an avenue towards happiness, while the knowledge of mortality puts its apparent glory into question.

Form and critical observation. Phrases such as "the essence of life" connect desire with philosophical reflection. A simple opposition between eroticism and renunciation does not adequately describe the song.

Song 15 | Original p. 27 | The Secret Language of the Confidante

Close reading. Conversation with a companion or confidante allows the concealed pain of love to unfold. The friend appears as listener, critic, and possible helper.

Form and critical observation. Repetition of forms of address gives the lyric dramatic quality. The "I" of the character's speech and the poet's final signature voice belong to distinct levels.

Song 16 | Original p. 28 | Imagining a Land Without Nature's Music

Close reading. The image of a land without cuckoos or bees suggests the absence of an atmosphere suffused with love. Natural sounds can both delight the heart and intensify the pain of separation.

Form and critical observation. The pairing of cuckoo and bee is a familiar erotic convention. Here its negation becomes the principal means of constructing meaning.

Song 17 | Original p. 29 | Patience, Separation, and an Unsettled Mind

Close reading. Mere advice to be patient cannot heal the wound of separation. Restlessness, the weight of time, and an insistence on the personal truth of love converge in the song.

Form and critical observation. Negative sentences and exhortative verbs create emotional tension; a simple lesson about patience in love would suppress the lyric's conflict.

Song 18 | Original p. 30 | Calling to the Beloved Far Away

Close reading. Remembering a beloved living abroad, the heroine feels absence within every activity of life. The outer season and her inner separation intensify each other.

Form and critical observation. The invocatory style is particularly suitable for a sung tradition. The difference between metaphor and self-address should remain visible in interpretation.

Intratextual connection. Read against the nights of separation in Songs 9 and 50, the heroine's experience of time becomes a continuous movement of metaphor.

Song 19 | Original p. 32 | Family Honour versus Attachment

Close reading. References to lineage, propriety, and social reputation reveal external control over romantic relationships. The heroine challenges the conflict between desire and accepted custom.

Form and critical observation. The sequence of value-laden terms brings a social structure before the reader. The speaker's resistance cannot be reduced to a narrow moral lesson.

Song 20 | Original p. 34 | A Brief Drama of a Meeting in Solitude

Close reading. Meeting the beloved in seclusion, sudden embarrassment, and bodily closeness produce an intimate psychological scene. Love is presented not as a fixed sentiment but as a process of movement and fleeting response.

Form and critical observation. Verbs of motion and indications of dialogue give the song a theatrical character. The events elaborated in the editor's prose reading may extend beyond what the original lyric actually implies.

Song 21 | Original p. 35 | Moon Imagery and the Vow of Love

Close reading. The moon in the sky, and images of light and darkness, relate love's inner illumination to the wider environment. A dialogue between lovers develops into a reflection on the meaningfulness of life.

Form and critical observation. The conventional poetic epithet kalanidhi, "treasury of radiance," acquires a fresh relation to the poem's particular meaning. Ornate language and popular speech coexist.

Song 22 | Original p. 36 | Sweet Speech, a Hard Heart

Close reading. The contrast between words as honey and a mind as hard as a thunderbolt is the principal image of betrayal in love. The heroine's experience exposes the distance between seductive language and insensitive conduct.

Form and critical observation. The opposition of honey and thunderbolt achieves characterisation in very few words. It is a clear example of verbal ornamentation.

Song 23 | Original p. 38 | The Courtyard, the Gaze, and Intimacy

Close reading. The domestic courtyard becomes a theatrical space for lovers to look at one another. Movement of the eyes, gesture, and embarrassment form a language preceding spoken exchange.

Form and critical observation. Local domestic imagery brings out the particular Maithili quality of the lyric. The courtyard is a meeting place of social scrutiny and private desire.

Song 24 | Original p. 39 | The Fulfilment of Birth and Attachment

Close reading. The fulfilment of human birth is associated with the experience of love. Attachment becomes a force leading the lover from

incompleteness towards fullness, though the fear of disappointed expectation accompanies it.

Form and critical observation. The brief statement contains an important existential view. The personal and universal meanings of love must be distinguished.

Song 25 | Original p. 40 | The Cry of "O Friend"

Close reading. Repeatedly calling upon her confidante, the heroine reveals her suffering. Waiting for love, bodily agitation, and the intolerable passage of time sharpen her self-disclosure.

Form and critical observation. The invocation is the sonic centre of the song. Its musicality arises not only from metre but from the recurrence of direct address.

Song 26 | Original p. 41 | Memory of the Beloved and Forgetfulness of Self

Close reading. Without the beloved, the mind cannot rest. The body, home, and daily tasks appear without meaning as memory overshadows the present.

Form and critical observation. The conflict between presence and absence is brought forward through repeated sounds and expressions. Images of beauty such as gold require interpretation within their particular context.

Song 27 | Original p. 42 | A Burning Heart and the Heat of Life

Close reading. Images of heat transform emotional suffering into a bodily temperature. The heroine's anguish becomes inseparable from her experience of the season.

Form and critical observation. The interrelation of season, heat, and desire is a feature of Vidyapati's figurative language of love. Reading the heat merely as a description of weather would be inadequate.

Song 28 | Original p. 43 | Attachment and Self-Surrender

Close reading. The heroine's longing comes into conflict with social restrictions. Even as she accepts the risks of love, she refuses to deny her feelings.

Form and critical observation. The direct conversation with the friend and the poet's final statement create two voices. The first should not be suppressed in favour of a convenient interpretation of the second.

Song 29 | Original p. 44 | The Repeated Cry of "O Hari"

Close reading. The repeated invocation of the beloved, Hari, shows patience breaking down. Recollection and its recurring surges cause the pain of separation to begin anew, again and again.

Form and critical observation. Repetition of the same address blurs the boundary between prayer and romantic longing. Both devotional and erotic interpretations remain possible.

Song 30 | Original p. 45 | Rain and the Contradictions of Separation

Close reading. Rain brings renewal to the outer world but intensifies the suffering of the heroine separated from her beloved. A season normally associated with joy becomes adverse for the woman in separation.

Form and critical observation. The reversal of seasonal expectation is the central artistic device. Sounds and suggestions of running water sustain the song's musicality.

Song 31 | Original p. 46 | Confiding Sorrow to a Friend

Close reading. The heroine addresses her suffering not directly to the beloved but to her confidante. This mediation reveals a female community underlying the language of love.

Form and critical observation. The rhythm of "O friend" carries the emotions. The interplay of exclamation and pause evokes pathos.

Song 32 | Original p. 47 | "My Madhava" and the State of Separation

Close reading. Remembering Madhava makes the heroine's everyday existence one of suffering. Descriptions of mental activity and tears reveal the absence of love as an abiding psychological condition.

Form and critical observation. The name Madhava can indicate both an earthly lover and a divine protagonist; the narrating voice and context must guide its interpretation.

Song 33 | Original p. 48 | Letters, News, and Hope

Close reading. Longing for news of the beloved gives voice to the heroine's expectation. Imagining a letter or message is an attempt to overcome distance, but uncertainty increases her restlessness.

Form and critical observation. The messenger motif gives lyric poetry narrative movement. The sounds closing individual lines suggest the duration of waiting.

Song 34 | Original p. 49 | The Desolation of the Beloved's Distant Journey

Close reading. In the sentiment of "My beloved, friend, has gone to a faraway land," the emptiness of the house, the lengthening of nights, and despair in love become apparent. Though the surrounding world continues its course, the heroine's inner time stops.

Form and critical observation. Numerous scenes within the expanded lyric become stages of one emotional state. When the editor's prose explanation turns them into a continuous story, it risks reducing the openness of the original song.

Intratextual connection. Compared with the compressed separation of Song 9, this song uses a fuller series of events to transform absence into a condition of everyday life.

Song 35 | Original p. 51 | The Mother-in-Law, Surveillance, and Women's Secrecy

Close reading. The ageing mother-in-law becomes the embodiment of familial supervision of the woman in love. The possibility of a secret encounter contends with scrutiny within the house, bringing social realism into an erotic lyric.

Form and critical observation. The arrangement of domestic characters creates dramatic tension. The heroine's desire should be understood as a response to regulation, not merely as cunning concealment.

Song 36 | Original p. 52 | Enumerating Virtues and Remembering the Beloved

Close reading. Remembering the beloved's beauty and qualities is an attempt to resist the pain of separation. Numerical lists and exaggerated counting suggest the boundlessness of emotion.

Form and critical observation. Enumeration becomes a form of ornamental expansion. Criticism should distinguish the literal meaning of the numbers from their emotional significance.

Song 37 | Original p. 54 | Direction and Compassionate Waiting

Close reading. References to north and south, wind, and paths extend waiting across a geographical space. The attempt to keep gazing towards the beloved's direction makes the mind's restlessness visible.

Form and critical observation. Directional references transform physical orientation into an emotional map, with a pronounced union of erotic feeling and sorrow.

Song 38 | Original p. 55 | One's Own Shadow as Madhava's Companion

Close reading. The heroine experiences echoes of her sorrow in body, vision, and memory. Madhava's absence narrows the distance between reality and imagination.

Form and critical observation. Intimacy of address and recurring recollection make the song deeply subjective. It should not be regarded simply as a fragment of an external plot.

Song 39 | Original p. 56 | The Incomparable Qualities of Love

Close reading. Praising the beloved's virtues reveals the distinctive place occupied by love in the heroine's mind. Personal experience asserts itself at the limits of ordinary reasoning.

Form and critical observation. Hyperbole gives love its autonomous scale of value. The coexistence of affirmation and experiential doubt also deserves scrutiny.

Song 40 | Original p. 57 | A Premonition of the Beloved's Arrival

Close reading. The possibility of the beloved's arrival alters the heroine's movements, her preparations at home, and the direction of her thoughts. A glimpse of hope energises the body's language.

Form and critical observation. The sequence of actions creates a small dramatic scene. The opposing sensations of absence and possible reunion occur together.

Song 41 | Original p. 58 | A Meeting and the Dialogue of the Eyes

Close reading. Gestures, looks, and physical movements convey the lovers' affection. The conflict between shyness and attraction is more dramatically compelling than a static description of emotion.

Form and critical observation. The arrangement of bodily details is a poetic strategy of showing. The sense of the characters' active consent should not be overlooked.

Song 42 | Original p. 59 | Inexperience at the First Union

Close reading. The first intimate meeting brings together hesitation, curiosity, and apprehension. The poet treats inexperience as a component of the heroine's emotional complexity.

Form and critical observation. Suggestion is especially important in the description of union. It is unnecessary to expand every hint into an assertion about a literal event.

Song 43 | Original p. 60 | Seeing the Beloved in a Dream

Close reading. A dream offers momentary compensation for separation. On waking, the renewed emptiness makes the happiness of the dream even more painful.

Form and critical observation. The dream is not a replica of reality but a structure of desire. Shifting time is a significant formal feature.

Song 44 | Original p. 61 | Home, Memory, and a Friend's Support

Close reading. The domestic world becomes a setting for the heroine's suffering in love. What she tells her confidante takes the form of self-recognition.

Form and critical observation. The simplicity of household speech gives the lyric something of the quality of a folk song. The editor's Hindi-influenced prose interpretation needs to be compared with the idiom of the original Maithili.

Song 45 | Original p. 62 | Forest, Town, and Movement

Close reading. References to a grove or town indicate the possibility of meeting and the fear of separation. Even as love remains private, its world is shaped by routes, journeys, and time.

Form and critical observation. Changes of place stand for changes in the heroine's mind. The metaphor of the path admits several layers of reading.

Song 46 | Original p. 63 | Obstacles to Love and Self-Restraint

Close reading. Confronting actual obstacles in separation, the heroine struggles to maintain composure and patience. Her effort to escape memories of the beloved only intensifies those memories.

Form and critical observation. Repeated prohibitive statements create a paradox. This is not a passive declaration of despair but an active conflict within consciousness.

Song 47 | Original p. 64 | A Tongue of Flame and the Burning Heart

Close reading. The image of fire brings the intensity of suffering caused by love into sharp focus. Portraying body and mind in the same heat joins longing with sorrow.

Form and critical observation. The literal and suggested meanings of the fire image differ. The movement between popular expression and poetic metaphor is central to the song's beauty.

Song 48 | Original p. 65 | Extreme Separation and Doubt About Life

Close reading. Separation from the beloved appears to weaken the will to continue living. Life, recollection, and the apparent impossibility of reunion bring the poem to the height of karuna rasa.

Form and critical observation. Intense exaggeration is a dramatic expression of feeling. It should not be read as the speaker's literal plan of action.

Song 49 | Original p. 66 | A Direct Complaint to Madhava

Close reading. Addressing the beloved directly, the heroine places responsibility for her suffering upon him. Anger and attachment remain present together.

Form and critical observation. Direct address creates the verbal illusion of the beloved's presence. The sequence of questions clarifies the duality of reproach and affection.

Song 50 | Original p. 67 | The Lengthening Night of Life

Close reading. The pain of enduring an entire night, waiting for morning, and experiencing a restless mind forms the song's central sense of time. The lengthening of night is not simply quantitative but a qualitative experience of separation.

Form and critical observation. The association of time with darkness provides the lyric's emotional thread. Repeated sounds intensify impatience.

Intratextual connection. Reading the song beside Songs 9, 18, and 34 discloses the experiential distance between "one night" and "one life."

Song 51 | Original p. 68 | The Coming of Spring and New Life

Close reading. Spring colours, winds, and the renewal of town and countryside create an atmosphere in which love reawakens. The relation of external celebration to inner desire is central.

Form and critical observation. The spring description is not a weather report but a poetic arrangement of stimulating determinants, uddipana vibhavas. Animated references to the natural world heighten its musical quality.

Song 52 | Original p. 69 | Affection, Reproach, and Speech

Close reading. The discrepancy between the beloved's feelings and behaviour becomes the heroine's question. Her expectation of sincere love gives voice to pain, hope, and helplessness.

Form and critical observation. Figurative description is combined with direct utterance. Choosing the contextually appropriate meaning from the various alternatives supplied in the glossary is a task of textual criticism.

Song 53 | Original p. 70 | Gaze, Neglect, and Self-Respect

Close reading. The heroine's distress emerges through her acute observation of the beloved's appearance and conduct. The self-respect born of neglect prevents love from becoming an uncomplicated surrender.

Form and critical observation. Repeated counterquestions, imperatives, and assertions give the song the structure of an inner debate; the boundary between entreaty and reproach remains unsettled.

Song 54 | Original p. 72 | Madhava, the Eyes, and Restlessness

Close reading. In Madhava's absence, the eyes' longing to see him becomes physical exhaustion. The heroine makes an impossible attempt to turn her mind away from her beloved.

Form and critical observation. The conjunction of eyes and heart creates the song's imagery. Attention must be paid to the distinct roles of the dialogue with the confidante and the poet's signature.

Song 55 | Original p. 73 | The Southern Wind and the Favourable Season

Close reading. References to the southern wind, flowers, and seasonal pleasures awaken the opposite sensation of anguish in the heroine. When the beloved is absent, a favourable natural world becomes emotionally adverse.

Form and critical observation. The direction of the wind functions as an important stimulating determinant, or uddipana-vibhava. The opposition of spring and separation gives the song its emotional architecture.

Intratextual connection. Compared with the cuckoo and bee in Song 16 and the rain imagery in Song 30, nature becomes a force of pleasure or pain according to the speaker's condition.

Song 56 | Original p. 74 | The Analogy of "A Lake Without a Lotus"

Close reading. The comparison of a lotus-less lake with a life without love expresses the inner indispensability of human attachment. Duty, support, and bonds of affection become mutually implicated.

Form and critical observation. A sequence of analogies lends material presence to an abstract emptiness. Not every element of the comparison should be reduced to a single literal meaning.

Song 57 | Original p. 76 | Resistance to Domestic Convention

Close reading. The heroine asserts her identity by resolving not to abandon her home and live in another household. Her language of refusal is particularly significant amid marital and familial pressures.

Form and critical observation. The recurrence of "I will not" gives negation the poetic form of autonomy. Her unmistakable voice should not be submerged beneath an editorial sermon on propriety.

Intratextual connection. In contrast to the supervision of domestic life in Song 35, the heroine's declaration of refusal here is linguistically more direct.

Song 58 | Original p. 78 | Fire and the Trial of Discernment

Close reading. The reference to fire creates a sensory intensity of desire, fear, and suffering. The heroine recognises the risks imposed by society, yet her attraction to love continues to produce a decisive conflict.

Form and critical observation. The adverse metaphor serves as a means of self-assessment. Harsh and hyperbolic speech should not automatically be treated as a factual account of literal conduct.

Song 59 | Original p. 80 | Gauri's Courtyard and the Humour of Shiva's Wedding

Close reading. Gauri's courtyard, the wedding party, and the family's responses invest Shiva's world with the colours of folk humour. Spirituality enters the everyday scene of domestic life.

Form and critical observation. The mythological figures Shiva and Gauri appear alongside laughter and familiar household speech. The song's inclusion in a section on erotic sentiment reveals the difficulty of rigid classification.

Intratextual connection. Songs 60–66 demonstrate how folk humour situates the Shiva–Gauri episode within the domain of women's experience.

Song 60 | Original p. 81 | The World of Bhoginia and the Ironies of Marriage

Close reading. Through an address to the mother and an account of marital circumstances, the song exposes the ironies of happiness and sorrow in ordinary domestic life. Elevated mythological material turns into the practical anxieties of women.

Form and critical observation. Colloquial sentences, satire, and intimate forms of address evoke folk theatre. To call the piece merely a devotional song would be inadequate.

Intratextual connection. The courtyard in Song 59 and the matrimonial ironies in Song 62 continually develop this domestic folk setting.

Song 61 | Original p. 82 | An Appeal to the Mother and Social Unease

Close reading. Uneasiness about marriage, family, and intimate relationships is expressed before the mother. Tension arises between a woman's search for support and the pressure of social ritual.

Form and critical observation. Shifts in the speaking voice require attention: folk narrative, dialogue, and the poet's signature occupy different positions.

Intratextual connection. Between the personal resistance of Song 57 and the social satire of Song 62, this song introduces the tonal element of maternal address.

Song 62 | Original p. 84 | Satire on an Ill-Matched Marriage

Close reading. Questions of age, appearance, family, and compatibility are raised through laughter. The Shiva–Parvati episode can also be read as a critique of prevailing matrimonial arrangements.

Form and critical observation. The characters' anger should be read through popular expressions and suggested meanings. Mythological narrative should not be presented in its entirety as an event of documented history.

Intratextual connection. Songs 59, 60, and 63 explore different domestic aspects of the same group of religious figures; humour, therefore, is not inherently opposed to devotion.

Song 63 | Original p. 85 | The Repeated Cry "O Shiva"

Close reading. Address to Shiva, descriptions of his appearance, and exchanges of accusation and defence produce familiarity and laughter. Here devotion and popular life maintain no formal distance from each other.

Form and critical observation. The repeated invocation of the deity resembles the conversational idiom of a prayer-song; the humanisation of the god is the principal formal device.

Intratextual connection. Read alongside the amusement concerning Shiva's bull in Song 66, the song discloses a folk-poetic tradition of humanising the divine.

Song 64 | Original p. 86 | Royal Patronage and the Poet's Self-Awareness

Close reading. The closing indication of a courtly environment may be read as evidence of the poet's social position. The poet locates his composition among human relationships, beauty, and the world of his patrons.

Form and critical observation. The occurrence of names such as King Rupanarayana demands textual verification. Neither the poet's signature nor a panegyric should be mistaken for the entire subject of the poem.

Intratextual connection. Comparison with the dream and royal references in Song 86 permits reflection on the cultural bridge between poetic praise and love lyric.

Song 65 | Original p. 87 | The Incomparable Quality of Love

Close reading. Love's influence surpasses ordinary reasoning and the calculation of profit and loss. In celebrating love's qualities, the song acknowledges its uncertain, difficult, and profound nature.

Form and critical observation. Its concentrated statements approach the manner of didactic verse; the method of connecting aphorism with personal feeling deserves attention.

Song 66 | Original p. 88 | Shiva's Bull and Comic Sentiment

Close reading. References to the bull, the mount, the prospective husband, and contrasts in appearance create Shiva's singular image. Popular perception sees the mythological deity as an extraordinary, even comically improbable, bridegroom.

Form and critical observation. The combination of strange visual details and opposing attributes generates humour. The song is not simply praise of Shiva but a theatrical recreation grounded in social life.

Intratextual connection. This comic scene should be read with the Shiva–Parvati songs 59–63; to classify it as divine praise alone would erase its satirical dimension.

Song 67 | Original p. 89 | The Treasury of Jewels and the Restraint of Desire

Close reading. The sea and its jewels invite a comparison between material wealth and human desire. Love or honour emerges as a value distinct from possessions.

Form and critical observation. Simile and interrogative speech are aphoristically concise. Interpretation demands care over the context of the form of address actually used in the text.

Song 68 | Original p. 90 | Body, Mind, and Remembrance of the Name

Close reading. The name of Hari or the beloved opens the field of loving surrender towards devotion. There is a tension between the body's impermanence and the enduring relationship expressed through the name.

Form and critical observation. The repetition of a name is possible in both erotic and devotional discourse; the choice of one interpretation should not exclude the other.

Song 69 | Original p. 91 | The Folk Image of Cowries and Betel Leaves

Close reading. Concrete popular references to cowries and betel leaves raise questions of worldly exchange, honour, and affection. Everyday objects make possible reflection on the significance of relationships.

Form and critical observation. A practical word such as "cowrie" connects poetic language with the folk economy; metaphor should not be mistaken for a literal description of trade.

Song 70 | Original p. 92 | The Opposition of Sandalwood and Fire

Close reading. The coolness of sandalwood and the opposing heat of fire or separation evoke the unbearable pain of love. Feeling becomes a multisensory experience of touch, fragrance, and temperature.

Form and critical observation. A sequence of opposed sensations creates an urgent rhythm. Both spiritual and worldly interpretations remain open.

Intratextual connection. The fire of Song 47 and the wind of Song 55 help to construct an extended imagery of bodily heat and coolness.

5. "The Poet's Mind": Separate Readings of Songs 71–100

This section examines Songs 71–100 under the heading "The Poet's Mind." The song numbers and opening page references follow the contents of the original collection.

Song 71 | Original p. 93 | Service, Play, and the Poet's Self-Expression

Close reading. Opening the section on the poet's mind, references to life as play and to the spirit of service introduce a fresh perspective on the poet's experience. The voice becomes more self-examining as it moves away from the heroine's private anguish.

Form and critical observation. The shift between sections should not be mistaken for an absolute break in subject; the earlier lyric rhythms and ethical intimations remain present here.

Intratextual connection. Juxtaposing this opening song with the dance in Song 81 and the awareness of transience in Song 94 reveals the emotional range of "The Poet's Mind."

Song 72 | Original p. 94 | Floral Adornment and the Instability of Beauty

Close reading. A world fashioned from flowers brings together visible beauty, delicacy, and the possibility of destruction. The poet places the aesthetic pleasure of material adornment within the passage of time.

Form and critical observation. Floral imagery engages both sight and scent. In editorial interpretation, the difference between a simile and an actual object must be examined.

Song 73 | Original p. 96 | Day, Night, and Fleeting Happiness

Close reading. The passage of the day, the hazards of life, and the pursuit of lasting happiness constitute the song's central philosophical concern. The youthful body and the foundations of worldly existence appear impermanent.

Form and critical observation. The repetition of temporal references produces the effect of ethical or didactic song, yet the individuality of feeling prevents it from degenerating into dry instruction.

Song 74 | Original p. 97 | Sudden Suffering and Life's Uncertainty

Close reading. An unexpected event or change of feeling brings the insecurity of life into view. The poet recognises human limitations through abrupt changes in time and circumstance.

Form and critical observation. A temporal exclamation such as "today itself" lends immediacy to the song; the experience may be understood at both physical and symbolic levels.

Song 75 | Original p. 98 | Sleep, Waking, and the Struggle of Consciousness

Close reading. The movement of the mind between sleeping and waking becomes a crisis of lived experience. The urgency of desired pleasure and prudent decisions about life are in conflict.

Form and critical observation. Recurrent dream imagery deepens the meaning; care is required in establishing whether the identity of the speaker changes.

Song 76 | Original p. 99 | Lotus, Lake, and Affection

Close reading. The imagery of lake and lotus becomes a metaphor for the emergence of love, its fragility, and its dependence on circumstance. Without affection, beauty seems lifeless.

Form and critical observation. Though the lotus is a traditional image, its particular function here is relational interdependence; its meaning extends well beyond a description of beauty.

Song 77 | Original p. 100 | Images of Sensuous Grace and Gesture

Close reading. The poet's gaze rests on the body's gestures, gait, glance, and modest hesitation. Feeling emerges through intimations of union, reaching the reader as a visual experience rather than as a statement.

Form and critical observation. The conventional head-to-toe description of beauty is joined to the brevity of song. Bodily detail must be read in relation to the active gaze and the character's experience.

Song 78 | Original p. 102 | The Bodily Nature of Separation

Close reading. Separation makes itself felt in its effects on the body. Personal recollection and time intensify each other; poetic suffering is not merely mental.

Form and critical observation. Read as embodied longing, images of vision, fever, or weakness acquire emotional force. The entire meaning does not depend on any one figure of speech.

Song 79 | Original p. 103 | Young Radha and Love

Close reading. Radha's youth, modesty, and the intimations of her love for Krishna connect worldly erotic experience with the Vaishnava tradition. The relation between hero and heroine inhabits the space between a familiar myth and personal feeling.

Form and critical observation. The repetition of "new" creates freshness and energy. Devotional and erotic readings are not mutually exclusive.

Intratextual connection. Read with the new Vrindavan of Song 80 and the dance of Song 81, this song constructs a musical and natural world of Radha and Madhava's love.

Song 80 | Original p. 104 | The Natural World of "New Vrindavan"

Close reading. Beginning with "new Vrindavan, ever-new trees," the reiteration of newness creates an abundant picture of forest, flowers, bees, and love. Though Vrindavan is a natural location, it also becomes a realm of inward delight.

Form and critical observation. The alliterative recurrence of "new" gives dynamism to the rasa; the harmony of sight, scent, and sound is a major artistic achievement.

Intratextual connection. The youthful heroine of Song 79 and the blossoming grove of Song 82 together show the mutual transformation of season and love.

Song 81 | Original p. 105 | Dance Syllables and the Art of Sound

Close reading. Onomatopoeic sequences such as "dhingi-dhingi" give linguistic form to the rhythms of dance. Bodily movement, instrumental beat, and collective joy become structural elements of the poetry itself.

Form and critical observation. It would be an error to dismiss these imitative syllables as meaningless sounds. Their living context of singing and dancing extends beyond the printed page.

Intratextual connection. The visual "newness" of Song 80 and the audible dance syllables here reveal the intimate relationship between poetry and the performing arts.

Song 82 | Original p. 106 | A Scene of Love in a Flowering Grove

Close reading. A woodland bower full of flowers becomes a possible meeting place for lovers. Its natural privacy and atmosphere of attraction correspond to the heroine's state of mind.

Form and critical observation. Nature operates as an uddipana-vibhava, a stimulating determinant; its floral beauty should be read in conjunction with human desire.

Song 83 | Original p. 107 | Pride and the Appeal for Reunion

Close reading. The insistence on "now" creates pressure for an immediate decision. The beloved's pride, the appeal made to them, and the prospect of restoring the relationship become subjects of a sensitive dialogue.

Form and critical observation. Sentences of prohibition and entreaty create dramatic tension. The poet's signature is a concluding mark, not the voice of the dialogue's initial speaker.

Song 84 | Original p. 108 | The Conflict of Wakefulness and Joy

Close reading. Descriptions of the heart's longing and changes in the external world exhibit the instability of feeling. Hope of union and anxiety of mind appear together.

Form and critical observation. Repeated changes in sentence direction and the mode of addressing the confidante heighten the song's visual immediacy. It must not be treated as a fixed moral maxim.

Song 85 | Original p. 110 | The Seasons and a Tender Invitation

Close reading. Remembering the beloved amid a rainy or wintry setting, the poet turns natural features into a language of love. The mixture of beauty and suffering grants the season an emotional existence.

Form and critical observation. The literal meanings of seasonal markers should be distinguished from their use in evoking rasa. The succession of images gives the song its movement.

Song 86 | Original p. 111 | Dream, Royal Context, and Panegyric

Close reading. Dreams and the poet's references to royalty disclose the world of patronage in which he writes. Beyond the experience of the beloved, his social standing and panegyric diction open a new direction of interpretation.

Form and critical observation. Royal names, the poet's signature, and a dream narrator should not all be read as straightforward autobiography. Dating is impossible without comparison with independent historical evidence.

Intratextual connection. As in the references to royal patronage in Song 64, the poet's social location becomes a question for interpretation; concrete historical conclusions require other evidence.

Song 87 | Original p. 112 | Parting and Self-Restraint

Close reading. Departure, promises, and expectations express the pain of inevitable change. The heroine or speaker attempts to detain the beloved or hold that person in memory.

Form and critical observation. The interaction of imperatives and supplication creates emotional subtlety. The section title does not in itself establish the gender of the speaker.

Song 88 | Original p. 113 | The Rama Narrative and Devotional Poetry

Close reading. References to Rama, the family of gods, familial duty, or royal figures summon a distinct world of religious narrative. Rama's presence within a collection of love songs demonstrates the plurality of Vidyapati's poetic range.

Form and critical observation. Names and relationships in the printed text allow one to identify the devotional subject. Resemblance to another Ramayana tradition requires separate textual evidence.

Intratextual connection. Read with the Shiva-related Songs 59–66 and the invocation of Madhava in Song 90, this song reveals the collection's religious diversity.

Song 89 | Original p. 115 | Dialogue with a Confidante and the Beloved's Beauty

Close reading. An exclamation such as "What shall I say, my friend?" gives voice to otherwise unexpressed pain. Descriptions of the beloved's face, gaze, and the longing for union create emotional intimacy.

Form and critical observation. The interrogative opening exposes the limits of self-explanation. The poet makes artistic use of the ineffability of feeling.

Song 90 | Original p. 116 | Remembrance of Madhava and Self-Surrender

Close reading. The repeated cry "O Madhava, O Madhava" fuses prayer and the call of love. Bodily suffering, the mind's yearning, and the hope of grace meet in one address.

Form and critical observation. This song is particularly important at the boundary of erotic and devotional expression. One reader may find devotion, another the sorrow of separation; both readings have textual foundations.

Intratextual connection. Comparison with the invocation of Hari in Song 29 and the parting scene of Song 97 develops this combined erotic and devotional sensibility.

Song 91 | Original p. 117 | The Awakening of the Mind and an Impermanent World

Close reading. The restlessness of the mind, the appeal of sensual desire, and the call for self-restraint turn the song towards a philosophy of life. The conscious mind's examination of its own instability is the central concern.

Form and critical observation. Didactic sentences and emotional expression bring ethical reflection into lyric poetry. Their conceptual differences should be made clear in interpretation.

Song 92 | Original p. 118 | A Question Addressed to the Beautiful Woman

Close reading. Directly addressing the "beautiful one," the speaker reflects on the instability of love and the meaning of promises. The relationship is marked by tested trust and unextinguished hope.

Form and critical observation. Counterquestions turn the reader not into a judge but into a witness of feeling. Changes in address must be registered.

Song 93 | Original p. 119 | Dishevelled Hair and the Beauty of the Eyes

Close reading. Vivid descriptions of loosened hair, the face, and bodily features create a delicate picture of physical beauty. Alongside its visual charm, the character's shyness, agitation, and private uncertainty become perceptible.

Form and critical observation. The sequence of bodily images privileges visual beauty; the figure should be read not as a passive object but as an active presence in the exchanges of love.

Song 94 | Original p. 120 | The Impermanence of "Life Is Not Lasting"

Close reading. The instability of life, the body, and time is directly articulated. The question of mortality connects the experience of love with a wider philosophy of human existence.

Form and critical observation. The repetition of "not lasting" turns philosophical thought into a memorable lyric expression; emotional unease accompanies its concise moral reflection.

Intratextual connection. Read together with the reflections on life's brevity in Songs 11 and 73 and the awareness of the moment in Song 100, it becomes an ethical thread running through the selection.

Song 95 | Original p. 121 | Sunrise and Remembrance of the Beloved

Close reading. The rising sun, the movement of birds, and the beginning of day bring freshness to the setting. Nature awakens, but remembrance of the beloved keeps the mind in a different condition of wakefulness.

Form and critical observation. Dawn is both visual and symbolic; the precise conjunction of a change in time with a change in feeling shapes the song.

Song 96 | Original p. 122 | Grace, the Cry of Compassion, and Refuge

Close reading. The appeal of an impoverished speaker expresses a need for assistance and shelter. The voices of love, devotion, and personal supplication merge.

Form and critical observation. Immediacy conveyed by words such as "now," along with pleading verb forms, draws readers into the speaker's distress. Any religious identification must remain anchored in textual evidence.

Song 97 | Original p. 123 | Hari's Departure and Separation

Close reading. Hari's departure transforms a visible relationship into recollection. The song presents a sequence of restraint, hesitation, waiting, and emotional self-effacement.

Form and critical observation. Verbs of movement and repeated address make separation immediate. The mythological name should not lead us to disregard the poem's worldly sensitivity.

Song 98 | Original p. 124 | Humility, the Earth, and Divine Orientation

Close reading. The body and mind's incapacity, remembrance of the name, and indications of divine support turn the poem into a spiritual confession. The individual recognises personal limitations and seeks help.

Form and critical observation. The relation between worldly helplessness and trust in the divine strongly suggests devotional rasa. The song is difficult to contain wholly within a category of erotic verse.

Song 99 | Original p. 126 | Arrows, Beauty, and Love's Wound

Close reading. Through the image of arrows from the eyes or from beauty itself, attraction becomes palpable as a wound. The poet composes the pleasure and pain of love within a single image.

Form and critical observation. Although the arrow is a conventional metaphor of erotic poetry, it lends particular force to this song's psychological condition. A literal weapon is not intended.

Song 100 | Original p. 127 | The Present Moment and the Transience of Life

Close reading. In the final song, the immediacy of "now" confronts human mortality and the fleeting nature of time. Tension between the mind's attachments and sound understanding gives the collection a reflective close.

Form and critical observation. The final placement is part of the editor's design: the selection moves from separation and beauty towards a philosophy of life. There is no evidence that this sequence was arranged by Vidyapati himself.

Intratextual connection. Reading the suffering of female birth in Song 7 alongside the consciousness of impermanence in Song 94 enables a philosophical dialogue between the collection's beginning and its conclusion.

6. The Heroine's Expression: Agency, Reserve, and Resistance

6.1 Not One but Many Forms of "the Woman's Mind"

The beloved woman's voice and Vidyapati's poetic voice are not always identical. The pride in Songs 1–3, the suffering of separation from an absent lover in Songs 9–18, intimate encounters in Songs 20–24, domestic surveillance in Song 35, and the language of refusal in Song 57 are not merely incomplete aspects of a single "woman"; they constitute diverse sites of experience. A critical strength of the selection is its attention to women's speech. Its limitation lies in the risk that the section title may encourage readers to define women primarily through suffering.

6.2 The Confidante Is More Than a Listener

The address "sakhi" transforms a woman's solitary inward experience into a social dialogue. The confidante is a potential medium of secrecy, advice, communication, self-examination, and assistance towards reunion. Comparing Songs 15, 25, 31, 33, 34, and 89 reveals the distinct linguistic functions of addressing a sakhi. To describe all these songs merely as a lover's lament would be to neglect the subtle structure of social communication.

6.3 The Pressure of Social Custom

Family honour (19), the household courtyard (23), the mother-in-law's watchfulness (35), familial restraint (57), and the satirical treatments of Shiva and Gauri's wedding (59–63) show the control exercised by social custom over intimate love. Within what society calls "honour," women's voices negotiate their desires. Yet the speakers should not be turned into direct manifestos of

contemporary theory: reticence, supplication, attachment, and resistance coexist in their speech.

7. The Structure of Rasa, Imagery, and Sound

7.1 Love in Separation and the Pathetic Sentiment

Suffering occasioned by absence abroad (9, 18, 34), the arduous night (50), fruitless waiting (43, 54), the burning of fire (47), and the emotional stimulation of the wind (55) present several forms of vipralambha-shringara, love in separation. What matters is that separation is not merely absence; it reconstructs the experience of time and the body. Nights lengthen, homes become empty, nature turns hostile, and self-address grows restless. The pathetic sentiment arises from within erotic feeling, and so it is inappropriate to imprison every song within a single category of rasa.

7.2 Union, Modesty, and the Heroine's Gaze

Songs 20, 23, 41, 42, 77, and 93 create different scenes of loving gazes, intimations of touch, gesture, shyness, and concealed dialogue. The rasa of union here is not a public declaration: it manifests itself moment by moment in a relationship sustained amid social risk. Narrative and pictorial qualities reinforce one another in these compositions.

7.3 Humour, Satire, and Praise

The songs concerning Shiva and Gauri, 59–66—particularly 59, 62, 63, and 66—give humour an unusual place amid the seriousness of love. The gods' strange attire, Shiva's bull, and matrimonial conventions take on new meaning through the eyes of ordinary women. Such irony need not be hostile to devotion; it may equally signify the religious intimacy of popular culture.

7.4 Phonetic Texture and Song

The life of a song extends beyond semantic content into its utterance. The repetition of "O Hari" (29), the call "O sakhi" (25), successive repetitions of "new" (80), the onomatopoeic dance syllables (81), and the refrain "not lasting" (94) make sound an active vehicle of meaning. A prose paraphrase of textual meaning cannot fully preserve these effects of rhythm, pause, resonance, and address.

7.5 Families of Related Images

Bees and cuckoos (10, 16), moon and darkness (21), lake and lotus (12, 56, 76), wind and rain (30, 55, 85), sandalwood and heat (70), and flowers, bowers, and Vrindavan (72, 79, 80, 82) are recurring images. The same natural object can signify hope in one place and separation in another. As context changes, the image acquires a different rasa. The selection thus brings into focus a particular strength of Vidyapati's poetic craft.

8. Language, Folk Consciousness, Dialogue, and Singability

Abbreviated sounds, variant forms, and regional usages in the original Maithili songs may each possess a distinct history. It is therefore preferable to preserve the originality of certain readings rather than "correct" them according to modern standard spelling. Writing criticism in "correct Maithili" does not justify forcibly altering the language of historical verses being quoted. The songs' original verbal forms must be protected as source material.

The voice of dialogue is essential to the poetry's existence. Sakhi, mother, beloved, Hari, Madhava, Shiva, and the poet himself: each addressee occupies a distinct social and emotional context. If the interpreter adds a phrase such as "she says," this is an explanatory introduction, not the literal text of the song. The present critique repeatedly maintains that distinction.

9. Shaiva, Vaishnava, Worldly, and Ethical Voices

The thematic diversity within this collection of Vidyapati's songs is genuine. Songs of popular Shaiva humour (59–66), Vrindavan and Radha–Madhava poetry (79–82), the confluence of spiritual and romantic address (29, 90, 97), Rama-related references (88), and the sense of transience (11, 73, 94, 100) all find a place in the same selection. To impose a rigid sectarian declaration on these differing voices without textual evidence would diminish the breadth of Vidyapati's poetic world.

Love and devotion intermingle through the name of Madhava. In one song the beloved's delayed arrival (32) is the subject, while in another the cry "O Madhava" (90) approaches an invocation of religious refuge. Critical interpretation should distinguish the indications provided by divine address, the speaker's position, the bodily character of love, and the tone of surrender.

The poet's signature and suggestions of royal patronage in Songs 64 and 86 invite attention. But these signs do not establish a historical date, a particular court, or episodes in the poet's private life. Modern research must compare internal textual evidence with manuscripts, early commentaries, royal inscriptions, and other edited versions.

10. Merits and Limitations of Editorial Glosses and Problems of the Text

10.1 The Usefulness of the Editorial Arrangement

The editor generally supplies source indications and meanings of difficult words after a song, followed by an explanation of the text—for example, Song 1 (original pp. 9–10), Song 12 (p. 23), Song 36 (pp. 52–53), and Song 88 (pp. 113–14). This three-level arrangement enables readers to move among vocabulary, subject matter, and context. The selection, contents, and final list of sources (p. 128) make the book a more useful object of study than an ordinary popular anthology.

10.2 Glossary and the Determination of Meaning

A word can take several context-dependent meanings. Dictionary definitions alone cannot settle words such as madhukar, Hari, barad, gaam, maan, sakhi, sar, thir, and agni. A useful procedure for researchers is first to understand the grammar and speaker of the original line; second, to examine the glossary; third, to identify new narrative details introduced in the explanatory paraphrase; and fourth, to record possible alternative interpretations.

10.3 The Difference Between Printed Source References and a Critical Edition

Brief references to other books or collections of songs are supplied beneath several poems; a list of abbreviated source titles also appears on page 128. This documentation is commendable. By itself, however, it does not constitute a comprehensive critical apparatus recording manuscript readings, variants, questions of authenticity, and editorial intervention for each song. In particular, the letter sequences of a longer work such as Song 88 or an onomatopoeic song such as Song 81 cannot be declared definitive without comparison with other editions.

10.4 Possible Extensions of Interpretation

At times, the explanatory prose expands a short original song through additional incidents, motives, or descriptions of a character's thoughts. This is a traditional interpretative practice, not necessarily an error. Readers should nevertheless distinguish between an assertion clearly supported by the original words and an editor's inference—such as an elaboration beginning "the confidante thought." The distinction is repeatedly underlined in this study.

10.5 Editorial Presentation of Women's Voices

The compiler's woman-centred perspective is an important critical intervention. It calls for two simultaneous precautions: first, the heroine's voice should not be subordinated; second, every song should not be reduced to one uniform discourse of female empowerment or female suffering. Humour concerning Shiva and Gauri, Radha and Madhava's love, the poet's ethical reflections, and references to royalty demonstrate this complexity.

11. General Conclusions and Directions for Further Research

This selection edited by Kunal introduces readers to Vidyapati's poetry through the intensity of women's experience. Its first seventy songs range across lovers, confidantes, domestic life, ethical expectation, separation, and the humanised world of divinities; in the final thirty, the poet's self-reflective voice, beauty, dance, Vrindavan, devotion, and an awareness of mortality become increasingly prominent. Yet the passage of feelings across the boundaries of the two sections is its true beauty.

An important conclusion of the present study is that Vidyapati's speaking voice is plural. Sometimes the heroine speaks for herself; sometimes the confidante becomes the medium; sometimes the poet changes voices; sometimes the mythological world of Hari–Madhava or Shiva–Gauri opens

up. These songs should not be homogenised under the label "love poetry." Nature carries contrary sentiments; popular speech generates exalted poetic meanings; and vocal performance is itself part of meaning.

While acknowledging the editor's contribution, one critical problem remains clear: readers must remain conscious of the distinction between the interpretative elaboration in a paraphrase and what the original song actually establishes. The volume is an important gateway into the texts. With a collation of variant readings from other sources, it could provide a more secure foundation for research on women's poetry, the theory of rasa, and the linguistic history of medieval Maithili.

A detailed study of textual variants through comparisons among edited song collections and manuscript traditions would raise further questions. Studies devoted to metre, singing traditions, folk usage, and women's speech could similarly extend our understanding of this selection.

12. Song-by-Song Page Index and Source Material

The following table gives the original printed page number for each of the hundred songs, enabling readers to move directly between the source book and this criticism. On several pages within the printed range 9–127, the gloss and explanation of a song continue onto subsequent pages; the table therefore indicates the opening page of each song.

Song	Page	Song	Page	Song	Page	Song	Page
1	9	26	41	51	68	76	99
2	11	27	42	52	69	77	100
3	12	28	43	53	70	78	102
4	14	29	44	54	72	79	103
5	16	30	45	55	73	80	104
6	17	31	46	56	74	81	105
7	18	32	47	57	76	82	106
8	19	33	48	58	78	83	107
9	20	34	49	59	80	84	108
10	21	35	51	60	81	85	110
11	22	36	52	61	82	86	111
12	23	37	54	62	84	87	112
13	24	38	55	63	85	88	113
14	25	39	56	64	86	89	115
15	27	40	57	65	87	90	116
16	28	41	58	66	88	91	117
17	29	42	59	67	89	92	118
18	30	43	60	68	90	93	119

Song	Page	Song	Page	Song	Page	Song	Page
19	32	44	61	69	91	94	120
20	34	45	62	70	92	95	121
21	35	46	63	71	93	96	122
22	36	47	64	72	94	97	123
23	38	48	65	73	96	98	124
24	39	49	66	74	97	99	126
25	40	50	67	75	98	100	127

Chapter 10

Rangayan: A Critical Study of Maithili Theatrical Consciousness

Folk Theatre, Performance, Linguistic Identity, and Theatre History

Rangayan: Kunal

Work reviewed: Rangayan (Theatre Criticism) | Author: Kunal | First edition: 2023 | Publisher: Ankita Prakashan Pvt. Ltd. | ISBN: 978-93-91925-67-3

Introduction to the Study

Kunal's Rangayan attempts to bring the many dimensions of Maithili theatre discourse into a single volume. It brings together essays on naach, folk drama, kirtaniya theatre, Salhes, contemporary Indian theatrical consciousness, people's theatre, dramatic writing, content, form, directors, audiences, institutions, literature, and the reciprocal relationship between literature and performance. Its concluding portion also includes conversations and essays on particular individuals. The collection's fundamental importance lies in its repeated insistence that Maithili theatre must be considered not merely as the history of printed plays, but in its relationship to performance and popular life.

The introduction, article titles, and thematic arrangement of the volume raise questions about the interplay of theatrical traditions, modernity, language, and theatrical practice. The thematic concerns of each essay, together with the critical questions they suggest, are examined below in the order of the table of contents.

The Arrangement of the Volume and the Method of Study

The contents are organised into four main sections: "Naach and Folk Theatre," "Contemporary Maithili Theatre," "Theatre," and "Conversations." Each listed subsection is given a separate entry below. The book begins with the author's preface (printed pp. vii–viii) and concludes with an entry on the future of Maithili theatre. The titles include brief poems and

interrogative formulations; not every contribution is therefore treated as belonging to a single prose genre.

Preface: The Author's Conception of Theatre

In the preface, the author considers the continuous relationship between long practical experience of theatre and reflection upon it. The insistence on placing drama in the contexts of stage production, acting, folk language, organisation, and society provides a link between the preface and the opening essays. The author acknowledges a commitment born of experience. A critic must recognise both the strength and the limitations of that position. Experience makes the writing vivid, but general historical claims require independent substantiation.

Critical Discussion of All Subjects in the Four Sections

Naach and Folk Theatre

01. Mithila's Culture and Folk Theatre [Printed p. 13]

Subject. At the centre of this essay is the insistence on understanding folk theatre through its interconnections with community life, language, cultural practices, and festivals.

Critical discussion. Performance space, social participation, and oral traditions cannot be separated from the written text when studying folk forms.

02. Naach and Kirtaniya: Form and Possibilities [Printed p. 21]

Subject. The aesthetics and theatrical possibilities of the naach and kirtaniya traditions constitute the subject.

Critical discussion. The interdependence of narration, singing, acting, dialogue, and collective ritual provides the principal basis for analysing the form.

03. Dramatic Forms of Folk Ballads [Printed p. 25]

Subject. Questions concerning the narrative craft of folk ballads and their transformation into drama are raised.

Critical discussion. Converting a folk ballad into a play requires rearranging the roles of narrator, singer, and character, as well as transitions in time and audience participation.

04. A Folk Theatre in Transition: Salhes Naach [Printed p. 31]

Subject. Changes in Salhes Naach are presented as an example of social and cultural transition.

Critical discussion. One can investigate the relationship between the folk hero's story, caste-based and social memory, and changing conditions of performance.

05. Kirtaniya Theatre [Printed p. 36]

Subject. The historical tradition and theatrical form of kirtaniya drama are examined.

Critical discussion. The encounter of song, performance, poetry, and devotion must be studied alongside verification of the sources behind historical claims.

06. The Components of Kirtaniya [Printed p. 40]

Subject. The constituent elements of kirtaniya performance are classified by naming practices, troupe organisation, language, entrances, presentation, and related criteria.

Critical discussion. Unlike more general essays, this piece offers a useful analytical framework for understanding particular elements of theatrical practice.

Contemporary Maithili Theatre

07. Contemporary Indian Theatre and Maithili [Printed p. 47]

Subject. The relationship of Maithili theatre to, and its differences from, diverse movements in Indian theatre are considered.

Critical discussion. Rather than simply opposing mainstream and regional traditions, it is useful to examine the relations among experimentation, institutions, language, and audiences.

08. Contemporary Maithili Theatre: Its Condition and Expectations (A Director's Perspective) [Printed p. 50]

Subject. The present condition of theatrical work and the expectations of directors are questioned.

Critical discussion. The relations among a director's artistic autonomy, ensemble discipline, rehearsal, and resources provide the basis for criticism.

09. Distinctive Identity and Maithili Theatre [Printed p. 54]

Subject. The distinctiveness and identity of Maithili theatre, and its relation to other theatrical traditions, are discussed.

Critical discussion. Distinctiveness must be found not merely in costume or pronunciation, but in lived social experience and the creation of a theatrical language.

10. Defining the Form of Maithili Theatre: In the Context of People's Theatre [Printed p. 59]

Subject. The form of theatre and its public responsibilities are examined from the perspective of people's theatre.

Critical discussion. Dialogue with the people and commitment to their concerns must be reconciled with artistic freedom and dramatic craftsmanship.

11. Theatre: End, Means, and Duty [Printed p. 64]

Subject. Theatre is examined at several levels: as art, as communication, and as social responsibility.

Critical discussion. Distinctions between means and ends should be connected to practical performance, audience response, and artistic discipline.

12. A Maithili Play Should Be a Maithili Performance [Printed p. 73]

Subject. The question concerns the theatrical identity of a language and the representation of local experience.

Critical discussion. A Maithili performance should not mean displaying conventional cultural signs alone; it should permit the creative presence of lived feeling and different social voices.

13. Dramatic Tendencies and Theatre in the Language [Printed p. 77]

Subject. The interrelationship between theatrical tendencies and theatre grounded in language is the principal concern.

Critical discussion. Attention must be given to spoken language, bodily expression, stage rhythm, and the plurality of local dialects.

14. Theatre: Truth and Form [Printed p. 80]

Subject. The relation between representing truth onstage and the autonomy of artistic form is considered.

Critical discussion. The truth of the stage is not a direct imitation of reality; it is an experience constructed through dramatic arrangement and acting.

15. Social Consciousness in Maithili Playwriting, 1960–1990 [Printed p. 85]

Subject. The historical relationship between playwriting and social consciousness in the specified period is examined.

Critical discussion. Historical conclusions require separate evidence concerning plays, publication dates, performances, and critical responses.

16. The Shortage of Writing [Printed p. 91]

Subject. The lack or insufficiency of dramatic writing is raised as a problem.

Critical discussion. The reasons for any shortage cannot be determined without distinguishing the number of works, their suitability for performance, training, and opportunities for publication.

17. Presenting Dramatic Subject Matter on the Maithili Stage [Printed p. 96]

Subject. The development and staging of material suited to the theatre is examined.

Critical discussion. The presence of a theme in the written text does not guarantee its effectiveness in performance; visual action, time, rhythm, and audience receptivity must also be considered.

18. The State and Direction of Theatre in Modern Mithila [Printed p. 100]

Subject. Conditions of theatrical activity in modern Mithila and its future directions are discussed.

Critical discussion. Rehearsal space, training, economic organisation, audience development, and local institutions must be included in debates about theatrical artistry.

19. The Story of Art and Mithila: An Introduction to the Debate [Printed p. 112]

Subject. The piece introduces a discussion of the relationship between art and Mithila's cultural condition.

Critical discussion. Art's relationship with social life should be made a subject of critical inquiry, not merely an occasion for declarations of cultural pride.

20. A Narrative Context: Culture, Anti-Culture, and the Enlightened Public [Printed p. 118]

Subject. The argument concerns the moral division between culture and anti-culture, and the role of enlightened people.

Critical discussion. Assessing culture requires a critical examination of class, relations with the people, artistic freedom, and claims to moral authority.

Theatre

21. The Expression of Popular Life in Maithili Drama [Printed p. 127]

Subject. The question concerns representing the lives of ordinary people onstage.

Critical discussion. Staging popular life should be understood not simply as gathering folk material but as recreating social conflicts and voices in a living form.

22. Maithili Journalism, Literature, and Theatre [Printed p. 133]

Subject. The relationship of intellectual dialogue among literature, journalism, and performance is examined.

Critical discussion. This raises the question of how important the distinct functions of theatre criticism and news reporting are in documenting theatrical movements.

23. Theatre and Literature: One [Printed p. 135]

Subject. The differences and similarities between dramatic writing and a theatrical production are questioned.

Critical discussion. Drama is also a literary genre, but images, sound, and actors create meanings of their own in performance.

24. Theatre and Literature: Two [Printed p. 138]

Subject. A second side of the preceding debate further explores the relationship between the theatrical art and literature.

Critical discussion. These two essays should be read as a connected discussion while their separate arguments are independently examined.

25. Theatre and Literature: The Stage [Printed p. 140]

Subject. The discussion places the independent artistic existence of theatre at its centre.

Critical discussion. Particular attention should be paid to the collective creation of theatrical meaning by playwright, director, actor, technical collaborators, and audience.

26. Drama Competitions [Printed p. 142]

Subject. The role of competitions and their possible limitations can be considered in relation to theatrical organisations.

Critical discussion. Prizes should not be the sole measure of quality; the value of sustained rehearsal and experimentation also requires consideration.

27. The Process of Establishing Identity [Printed p. 145]

Subject. Artistic identity is considered as something created over a prolonged period.

Critical discussion. The subtle cooperation or tension between identity and experiment calls for careful examination.

28. Who? [Printed p. 148]

Subject. The brief interrogative title opens possible questions about agency, identity, or responsibility in theatrical criticism.

Critical discussion. The specific argument cannot be established from the title alone. This essay especially requires line-by-line comparison with its full text.

29. Theatrical Dreams and Alternatives [Printed p. 151]

Subject. The subject is the relationship among theatrical futures, aspirations, and practicable alternatives.

Critical discussion. Idealistic commitments should be assessed in conjunction with the social and institutional conditions necessary for their implementation.

30. Some “Dramas” in the Name of Drama [Printed p. 154]

Subject. The title suggests the possibility of an ironic critique of contradictions within theatrical practice and culture.

Critical discussion. Its satirical implication should not be substituted for the author’s actual argument when drawing conclusions.

31. Expectations of Maithili Theatre [Printed p. 158]

Subject. Expectations of theatrical practitioners and necessary changes form the subject.

Critical discussion. It is fruitful to divide such expectations into clear criteria: writing, production, audiences, institutions, and training.

32. Theatricality and Maithili Theatre [Printed p. 161]

Subject. Questions concerning the aesthetics of theatricality and the specific character of Maithili theatre are brought face to face.

Critical discussion. The meaning of theatricality emerges from a complex combination of acting, stage time, visual relationships, and collective experience.

33. Our Own Story of Theatre [Printed p. 166]

Subject. The title suggests a personal account of theatrical experience and practice.

Critical discussion. The testimony of personal experience should not be treated as an unmediated equivalent of general history.

34. Pamar: Traditional Theatre of Every Community [Printed p. 169]

Subject. The contents mention a traditional theatrical form belonging to a particular community.

Critical discussion. Definitive claims concerning social origins or genre-specific characteristics require an exact reading of both the name and the full text.

35. Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—1 [Printed p. 171]

Subject. This is the first instalment in a series of imaginative poetic utterances concerning theatre.

Critical discussion. The material should be approached not as a dramatic essay but as poetry or short creative writing, with attention to figures of speech, voice, and theatrical imagery.

36. Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—2 [Printed p. 176]

Subject. The second part of the series of poems on theatre.

Critical discussion. Its thematic connection with the preceding poem should be considered without losing sight of its independent textual form.

37. Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—3 [Printed p. 185]

Subject. The third instalment of the theatrical poems.

Critical discussion. The generic boundary between the symbolic language of performance and poetry must be kept in view.

38. Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—4 [Printed p. 193]

Subject. The fourth part of the sequence of theatrical poems.

Critical discussion. Studying each instalment separately can disclose repetitions, changes, and rhythms of expression.

39. Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—5 [Printed p. 202]

Subject. The fifth part of the sequence.

Critical discussion. All five compositions must be counted and given their due place in the study. Conclusions about the architecture of the complete sequence require comparison with the original text.

Conversations

40. Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary's Plays [Printed p. 213]

Subject. A conversation centred on a figure associated with plays and theatrical work.

Critical discussion. The speakers, context, and question-and-answer form should be examined while distinguishing opinions expressed in conversation from biographical facts.

41. Life and Our Theatre: The Life of Prakash Natak [Printed p. 219]

Subject. A conversation concerning the mutual relationship between lived experience and theatrical experience.

Critical discussion. Independent archival sources are needed to verify the historical accuracy of biographical statements.

42. Oh, Shrikant Ji! [Printed p. 226]

Subject. A memoir or conversational piece about Shrikant Ji appears in the contents.

Critical discussion. The intimacy of its conversational voice should be read with an awareness of differences among factual information, evaluation, and recollection.

43. Folk Elements in the Plays of Pandit Govind Jha [Printed p. 230]

Subject. The presence of folk elements in Pandit Govind Jha's plays is under consideration.

Critical discussion. Assessing folk elements requires separate attention to their roles in plot, song, language, characters, and stage experiment.

44. Play and Naach: Theatrical Drama [Printed p. 234]

Subject. The relationship of play, naach, and theatre is explored.

Critical discussion. The reciprocity between the spontaneity of play and the discipline of dramatic construction is a productive critical question.

45. The Future of Maithili Theatre [Printed p. 251]

Subject. The final subject concerns the future possibilities of Maithili theatre.

Critical discussion. This concluding piece should be connected to the theatrical outlook of the volume as a whole and examined against the criteria of institutional and creative possibility.

Integrated Assessment: The Questions Raised by the Work

Folk Theatre and Modern Dramatic Forms

The volume's first section invites us to regard popular performance not as peripheral entertainment but as a primary source of Maithili theatrical tradition. Forms such as kirtaniya and Salhes are interwoven with oral memory, music, the construction of roles, social organisation, and collective audience participation. Such material calls into question a linear theatrical history based exclusively on printed literature.

Linguistic Identity and Theatrical Practice

Linguistic identity is central to the search for the distinctiveness of Maithili theatre. Yet the language of the stage is more than dialogue: movement, sound, song, silence, pronunciation, and the relationship with an audience also belong to it. Unless the demand for a distinctive identity is connected with social diversity, the very conception of identity may become narrow.

Dramatic Text and Performance

The author's script constitutes one possibility; it becomes a complete theatrical event in the hands of actors and directors, through sets, lighting, sound, rehearsal, and an encounter with an audience. Setting literary standards beside independent criteria for performance makes the volume's debates more coherent.

Historical Evidence and the Place of Experience

Because the volume gathers writings produced at different times, it contains layers of contemporary cultural questions. First-hand testimony is valuable, but an impartial history of the people, institutions, dates, and productions concerned requires comparison among performance lists, periodicals, reviews, dramatic texts, and interviews.

Theatre Institutions, Training, and Audiences

The absence or strength of artistic institutions cannot be explained solely by the determination of individual artists. Rehearsal spaces, financial resources, audience engagement, the participation of women and emerging performers, the circulation of dramatic writing, and the critical archive must also be examined.

Critical Voice and Style

The opening essays employ a strongly argumentative and questioning voice committed to theatrical practice. The tensions between folk tradition and classical learning, tradition and modernity, artistic truth and theatrical technique generate their critical energy. Yet more clearly documented examples and an equally serious consideration of opposing arguments would strengthen the authority of their judgements.

The Limitations of the Collected-Essay Form

Gathering writings from different periods and circumstances in one volume provides abundant material but also permits repetition, variations of voice, and conceptual inconsistency. A table recording each article's earlier publication, chronology of composition, and textual variants would enhance the academic usefulness of a future edition.

List of Essays in the Volume

The following list provides the names of all forty-five essays and subjects included in the original book, together with their opening printed page numbers.

No.	Essay / Subject	Page
1	Mithila's Culture and Folk Theatre	13
2	Naach and Kirtaniya: Form and Possibilities	21
3	Dramatic Forms of Folk Ballads	25
4	A Folk Theatre in Transition: Salhes Naach	31
5	Kirtaniya Theatre	36
6	The Components of Kirtaniya	40
7	Contemporary Indian Theatre and Maithili	47
8	Contemporary Maithili Theatre: Its Condition and Expectations (A Director's Perspective)	50
9	Distinctive Identity and Maithili Theatre	54
10	Defining the Form of Maithili Theatre: In the Context of People's Theatre	59
11	Theatre: End, Means, and Duty	64
12	A Maithili Play Should Be a Maithili Performance	73
13	Dramatic Tendencies and Theatre in the Language	77
14	Theatre: Truth and Form	80
15	Social Consciousness in Maithili Playwriting, 1960–1990	85
16	The Shortage of Writing	91
17	Presenting Dramatic Subject Matter on the Maithili Stage	96
18	The State and Direction of Theatre in Modern Mithila	100
19	The Story of Art and Mithila: An Introduction to the Debate	112
20	A Narrative Context: Culture, Anti-Culture, and the Enlightened Public	118
21	The Expression of Popular Life in Maithili Drama	127
22	Maithili Journalism, Literature, and Theatre	133
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25	Theatre and Literature: The Stage	140
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28	Who?	148
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31	Expectations of Maithili Theatre	158
32	Theatricality and Maithili Theatre	161
33	Our Own Story of Theatre	166
34	Pamar: Traditional Theatre of Every Community	169
35	Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—1	171
36	Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—2	176
37	Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—3	185
38	Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—4	193
39	Bulletin Meeting: Theatre Poems—5	202
40	Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary’s Plays	213
41	Life and Our Theatre: The Life of Prakash Natak	219
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44	Play and Naach: Theatrical Drama	234
45	The Future of Maithili Theatre	251

Conclusion

The critical importance of Rangayan lies in the diversity of its material and its questioning conception of theatre. From the sources of folk performance to the expectations of the modern stage, the collection locates Maithili theatrical practice within a shared field of art, language, community, and public reflection. It offers readers a valuable map of debate and researchers a guide to primary materials.

Detailed Bibliography

Printed books relating to the Maithili works under review and to the literary, theatrical, and comparative concepts discussed in this study. Publication details refer to the specified editions where available. Conceptual comparison should not be mistaken for evidence of direct historical influence.

A. Principal Works Reviewed

1. Kunal. Kusma-Salhes and Six Other Plays. First edition (hardbound), 2021. Ghaziabad: Antika Prakashan Pvt. Ltd. ISBN 978-93-88799-77-5.

2. Kunal, ed. Vidyapati's 100 Songs: Let No One Be Born a Woman. First edition, 2023. Ghaziabad: Ankita Prakashan Pvt. Ltd. ISBN 978-81-962063-0-7.

3. Kunal. Rangayan (Theatre Criticism). First edition, 2023. Ankita Prakashan Pvt. Ltd. ISBN 978-93-91925-67-3.

B. Indian Poetics and Textual Criticism

1. Bharata Muni. The Nāṭyaśāstra. Translated by Manomohan Ghosh. Calcutta: Asiatic Society of Bengal, 1951.

2. Anandavardhana. Dhvanyāloka of Ānandavardhana. Edited and translated by K. Krishnamoorthy. Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, second edition, 1982.

3. Kuntaka. The Vakrokti-jīvita of Kuntaka. Edited and translated by K. Krishnamoorthy. First edition, 1977. Dharwad: Karnatak University.

C. Theatre Theory, Dramatic Technique, and Cultural Studies

1. Aristotle. Poetics. Translated by Malcolm Heath. Penguin Classics, 1997.

2. Bertolt Brecht. Brecht on Theatre: The Development of an Aesthetic. Edited and translated by John Willett. New York: Hill and Wang, first American edition, 1964.

3. Lionel Abel. Metatheatre: A New View of Dramatic Form. New York: Hill and Wang, first edition, 1963.

4. Mikhail Bakhtin. Rabelais and His World. Translated by Hélène Iswolsky. Bloomington: Indiana University Press, Midland Book edition, 1984.

5. Konstantin Stanislavsky. An Actor Prepares. Translated by Elizabeth Reynolds Hapgood. New York: Theatre Arts, Inc., 1936.

6. Richard Schechner. Performance Theory. Revised and expanded edition. New York: Routledge, 1988.

7. Erika Fischer-Lichte. The Transformative Power of Performance: A New Aesthetics. Translated by Saskya Iris Jain. London and New York: Routledge, 2008.

8. Hans-Thies Lehmann. Postdramatic Theatre. Translated by Karen Jürs-Munby. London and New York: Routledge, 2006.

9. Eli Rozik. The Roots of Theatre: Rethinking Ritual and Other Theories of Origin. First edition. Iowa City: University of Iowa Press, 2002.

10. Eli Rozik. Generating Theatre Meaning: A Theory and Methodology of Performance Analysis. Brighton: Sussex Academic Press, 2008.

D. Comparative Philosophy and Other Theatrical Traditions

1. Martin Buber. I and Thou. Translated by Walter Kaufmann. New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1970.

2. Hannah Arendt. The Human Condition. Second edition; introduction by Margaret Canovan. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998.

3. Shimon Levy. The Bible as Theatre. Brighton: Sussex Academic Press, illustrated edition, 2000.

4. Elizabeth Wichmann. Listening to Theatre: The Aural Dimension of Beijing Opera. Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 1991.

5. Catherine C. Swatek. Peony Pavilion Onstage: Four Centuries in the Career of a Chinese Drama. Ann Arbor: Center for Chinese Studies, University of Michigan, first edition, 2002.

STUDY 10 / NIT NAVAL

Parmeshwar Kapari

CHAPTER 01

A Critical Study of Parmeshwar Kapari's Tales and Stories

Folktales, Mythological Narratives and Linguistic Craft

Introduction: Parmeshwar Kapari as a Storyteller

Parmeshwar Kapari, a senior Maithili writer living in Janakpurdham, is known primarily as a playwright. Yet his creative world also encompasses a rich body of stories and traditional tales that has not, to date, received the critical attention it deserves.

Kapari's narrative work can broadly be divided into five streams:

(a) Folktales in their pure form, outstanding examples being "Lachhminiya Kaniya" and "The Glory of Remembering Hanuman's Name."

(b) New interpretations of mythological tales: "Yajna-Sita," "Chhauri-Chhaura Sudyumna," "Lakshmi and Bali," "Austerity and Holy Company," and "God Who Dwells in the Heart."

(c) Didactic tales: "Education and Initiation" and "Number."

(d) Traditional tales and anecdotes: "Dog, Cat and Mouse" and "Gonu Babu at Home."

(e) Narrative poetry: "Dam" (an extended narrative poem, Sakshi).

Two elements lie at the centre of all these stories: the vitality of spoken Maithili and the social and cultural realities of Maithili life. Their conjunction gives his narratives a distinctive geographical and cultural identity.

A Critical Examination of the Stories

1. "The Glory of Remembering Hanuman's Name"

1(a). Plot

In Ravana's Lanka, the nine planetary deities, the Navagraha, are imprisoned, powerless and miserable. During the burning of Lanka, Hanuman sees them, enquires about their condition, breaks their bonds and sets them free. The Navagraha invite Hanuman to ask for a boon, but he answers, "Lord Rama is with me; I have no need to ask for any boon." The Navagraha then make a promise of their own accord: the nine planets will cause no suffering to anyone who chants Hanuman's name.

1(b). Analysis of Language

The work is an excellent specimen of Maithili. Forms such as "rahae," "hai," "ai," "aela," "hunkasabke" and "okrasabke" are natural Maithili usages and are not substantially different from the Maithili of Darbhanga and Mithila in India.

"As he went on setting Lanka ablaze, spreading fire hither and thither, Hanuman saw the nine planetary deities there, deprived of strength and power, looking almost dead and withered."

Expressions such as "agilaggi," "agarahi-pasahi" and "muil-vilai" attest to the living character of Maithili. The last expression, meaning "dead and withered," exemplifies the paired compound that forms part of the language's grammatical wealth.

1(c). The Question of Rasa

The devotional rasa predominates in this tale, but devotion is not its only emotional register. The pathos of the planets' helplessness and the heroic rasa of Hanuman's courage in breaking Ravana's fetters together produce a composite aesthetic experience. According to Anandavardhana's theory of dhvani, the principal suggestion is that "divine grace is obtained not by asking for it but through self-surrender." This suggestion operates at the level of implication, beyond the literal meaning.

1(d). Vakrokti, or Oblique Expression

From Kuntaka's perspective on vakrokti, the most strikingly oblique utterance is "With Him beside me, why should I ask any of you for a boon?" In conventional devotional logic, a devotee requests a boon and the Lord grants it. Here Hanuman reverses the logic and redefines devotion: "To ask for boons is a weakness of devotion." That reversal raises an ordinary tale to a philosophical plane.

1(e). A Navya-Nyaya Perspective

According to Gangesha's theory of verbal testimony, or shabda-pramana, the Navagraha's promise that whoever chants Hanuman's name will be free of suffering is an apta-vakya, the statement of a trustworthy authority. In Navya-Nyaya, such testimony has evidentiary value because its speakers, the planetary deities, are authoritative. Kapari makes this classical reasoning accessible through a folktale.

1(f). The Videha Perspective

The Hanuman narrative has a long history in Maithili literature. Kapari, however, presents it within a renewed geographical and cultural setting. When a Maithili storyteller from Janakpurdham in Nepal narrates the story of Rama, Ravana and Hanuman, the work possesses its own vernacular voice and standpoint.

2. "Lachhminiya Kaniya": Parmeshwar Kapari's Finest Folktale

2(a). Plot

An old man and an old woman live in a village. Their daughter-in-law is small and slight, "labkaniya," "chhotkhutiya bhutiya," yet remarkably capable in work and endowed with intelligence and understanding. One night a jackal cries out. The daughter-in-law knows the language of animals. The jackal tells her that two rubies are lodged in the thigh of a corpse floating down the river. Braving the danger, she retrieves the gems from the river, leaves the corpse for the jackal and returns home. Her mother-in-law misunderstands what happened and thinks the young woman has been eating a corpse. A commotion follows, and she is sent to her parents' house. On the way a crow speaks, and she understands its language too. The crow says that if a snake is offered milk on that day, it will reveal diamonds and pearls. She persuades her father-in-law to follow this advice. He agrees, offers the snake milk and parched grain, and obtains diamonds and pearls. The household becomes wealthy. Mother-in-law and daughter-in-law are reconciled, and the family lives in happiness and harmony.

2(b). Structural Analysis of the Folktale

According to the Russian folklorist Vladimir Propp's Morphology of the Folktale (1928), folktales possess a recognisable structure. "Lachhminiya Kaniya" follows this structure closely:

(i) Initial lack: poverty and the humiliation of the daughter-in-law.

(ii) Donors: the jackal and the crow, who impart knowledge to the daughter-in-law.

(iii) Helper function: the knowledge of animal languages, her exceptional power.

(iv) Test or challenge: the courage required to visit the river at night.

(v) Final victory: diamonds and pearls, followed by family reconciliation.

A distinctive feature of the Maithili-Mithila tradition, however, is the episode of the snake and its offering of milk at the conclusion. It is this additional element that gives the Maithili folktale its own imaginative specificity.

2(c). An Extraordinary Richness of Language

The most significant feature of "Lachhminiya Kaniya" is its wealth of vernacular vocabulary. The following clusters of words are precious elements of the living Maithili linguistic heritage:

"labkaniya," "harharahi khatbanari," "chhotkhutiya bhutiya," "chhagunae," "dhatpatae," "gundhunae," "paniae," "lobhae," "jhisi-bunnibala," "bikaral rait," "huan-huan," "jumus banhik," "habakka mari," "lattopato," "hathi-bardam," "dhukka-pharki," "dhipal aig-baul," "chhabkal dabkal," "pithiya-thok dhamakka," "nangtiñya rakmasani,"

"odhabadhak," "lohchhi jhantiyak," "pachhmuriya kanderiya," and "hapais-lapaikak."

These words remain alive in the spoken Maithili tradition. By gathering, preserving and according them literary dignity, Kapari makes perhaps his greatest contribution.

2(d). The Distinctive Female Protagonist

The daughter-in-law, described as "labkaniya, chhotkhutiya bhutiya," appears physically unremarkable. Yet she possesses the rare ability to understand animal speech. Known in the folk tradition as pashu-siddhi, this knowledge makes her exceptional. She goes alone to the river at night: courage. She extracts the jewels from a corpse: resourcefulness. She endures her mother-in-law's anger without collapsing: fortitude. She understands the crow and convinces her father-in-law: intelligence. She thus embodies Mithila's "Lachhminiya," an ideal woman who combines courage, wisdom and the auspicious prosperity associated with Lakshmi.

2(e). The Convergence of Devotional and Pathetic Rasas

In the middle of the story, the old woman's anger (raudra rasa) merges with the daughter-in-law's helplessness (karuna rasa). By the conclusion, however, these emotions resolve into shanta rasa, the rasa of tranquillity: "Thereafter, mother-in-law, daughter-in-law and all the others lived together in mutual affection, happiness and contentment." This is the conventional happy ending of the Maithili folktale, affirming an ideal of domestic life.

2(f). A Comparative Perspective

"Lachhminiya Kaniya" belongs to the Maithili "Sunari-Bahuriya" narrative tradition. Yet in many tales from that tradition the daughter-in-law is only a passive beneficiary: magic takes place on its own. Here she exercises courage and applies her intelligence herself. This difference matters. Kapari makes the daughter-in-law an agent, not merely a patient upon whom events act.

3. "Yajna-Sita": A Bold Rereading of Myth

3(a). Plot

Whenever King Rama performs a sacrifice, a golden image of Sita is made. A group of these sacrificial Sitas gathers at Rama's residence, distressed and neglected. One day they go to Rama together and ask for recognition. Rama invokes his vow of fidelity to a single wife: "I have married Sita, daughter of Janaka, the ruler of Mithila." The sacrificial Sitas ask, "If we participated in the sacrifice, why can we not participate in your life?" Finally Rama offers a resolution: in the Dvapara age, when he is incarnated as Krishna, they will become gopis. "All those sacrificial Sitas became gopis in Braj."

3(b). Literary Courage

This is among Kapari's boldest creations. In Maithili popular tradition Rama and Sita are sacred figures, and questioning their relationship is unusual.

Kapari nevertheless reconsiders it from Mithila's Sita-centred perspective: Sita as Janaka's daughter, a daughter of Mithila.

> *"When a sacrifice is performed, we are indispensable! / Without us it remains incomplete! / Does not the officiating sacrificer undertake it in our company?"*

In terms of scriptural reasoning, the argument is unassailable. A wife as her husband's other half is indispensable to the sacrifice: that is the Vedic injunction. By placing this argument in the mouths of the sacrificial Sitas, Kapari compels Rama to answer them.

3(c). Vernacular Feminism

This work is a notable example of a discourse of women's rights in Maithili folk literature. The sacrificial Sitas are not simply helpless women: they reason, present demands and understand their rights. "And yet you call yourself the ideal Maryada Purushottama, the supreme exemplar of righteous conduct?" This question opens a new chapter in the Maithili literature of Nepal.

3(d). Analysis of Dhvani

At the literal level, the narrative tells the story of the sacrificial Sitas. At the level of suggestion, however, Kapari communicates a profound message: "A society that makes use of women's labour but denies them rights is out of balance." From Anandavardhana's perspective, this suggested meaning is the very soul of the work.

3(e). Within the Tradition of Reinterpreting Myth

The Maithili poet Vidyapati (distinct from the earlier Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishwar) reconsidered mythological narratives in Bhūparikramā and Puruṣaparīkṣā. Kapari extends that tradition but brings to it a new social consciousness. This is an important dimension of Videha's parallel history.

4. "Chhauri-Chhaura Sudyumna": A Mythological Tale of Gender Transformation

4(a). Plot

King Vivasvan Manu and Queen Shraddha desire a son. The queen arranges a putrakameshti sacrifice but says, "Whenever a child comes, let it be a daughter." Through the force of this wish, a daughter, Ila, is born. By the age of five or seven, the child exhibits masculine behaviour. An enquiry reveals that the priest's incantation during the sacrifice had been intended to bring forth a son; the queen's wish had produced a daughter, but the masculine disposition remained. Through his ascetic power, Vasishtha transforms the girl into a boy named Sudyumna. Sudyumna enters a forest and, because it is the place of Shiva and Parvati's amorous recreation, becomes a woman there. The sage Budha falls in love, and a son, Pururava, is born. Vasishtha recites the Devi Bhagavata and transforms Sudyumna permanently into a man. A coronation follows.

4(b). Questions of Gender

The story is based on the Shrimad Devi Bhagavata Mahapurana (chapter 3). Kapari, however, retells it in the distinctive vernacular of Maithili. Gender transformation, or gender fluidity, is central to the narrative and intersects with modern debates about gender. The queen's wish, "Whenever a child comes, let it be a daughter," reverses society's customary preference for sons.

4(c). The Vitality of Language

"When their daughter Ila was four or five years old, all her bearing and manner began to seem masculine! She was a girl, yet in most things she acted and spoke like a boy."

"Bagay-bani" and "chhara jika" are distinctively Maithili expressions. The former describes bearing and manner, while the latter means "like a boy." Such expressions are not found in standard Maithili dictionaries.

4(d). A Navya-Nyaya Perspective

Under Gangesha's theory of vyapti, the story presents a chain of reasoning: (i) hearing the Devi Bhagavata, the cause (hetu), leads to (ii) Sudyumna's permanent male form, the conclusion (sadhya). Kapari, however, does not take this universal relation as the final truth, for Pururava, Sudyumna's son, provides evidence of the experience of motherhood. This is a dramatic use of the Navya-Nyaya technique of challenging a universal concomitance.

5. "God Who Dwells in the Heart"

5(a). Plot

At the beginning of creation, God gives human beings special intelligence and knowledge. But people begin to seek God whenever a problem, great or small, arises. God grows troubled. He hides in forests, mountains, ravines and caves, yet human beings always find him. At last he conceals himself in a place they will never think to search: their own hearts.

5(b). Vedanta and the Folk Imagination

A meeting of three traditions: the central idea of this tale draws upon three traditions: (i) Vedanta, with its "Tat tvam asi," and Brahman dwelling within oneself; (ii) Maithili folktale, in which the search for God leads at last to the heart. Kapari, however, does not present this metaphysics as dry philosophy but as a humorous tale. His portrait of troublesome people described as "ghaihar garaju, hehar-thethar matlabi lok," forever worrying God with their demands, is an appealing example of comic rasa.

5(c). Linguistic Play

"However far God might slip away and hide himself in some isolated corner, those importunate, obstinate and self-seeking people would still track him down."

"Aurh kat" means a secluded corner; "ghaihar garaju," someone excessively insistent; and "hehar-thethar," stubborn and unyielding. These clusters attest

to Maithili's vitality. "Ghaihar" and "hehar" are both expressive, sound-symbolic words whose meanings announce themselves when spoken.

5(d). The Philosophy of Humour

The idea of God being harassed exemplifies the anthropomorphism characteristic of folktales. Kapari makes this predicament philosophical: the one place where God is most readily available, the heart, is the very place human beings never seek him. This irony raises the folktale to the level of philosophical reflection.

6. "The Tale of Lakshmi and Bali" (The Raksha Bandhan Episode)

6(a). Plot

Because he is bound by a promise, Vishnu serves as gatekeeper at King Bali's door. Lakshmi waits in anxiety. Narada explains the reason, recalling the episode of Vamana and Bali. Lakshmi disguises herself, visits King Bali and ties a rakhi on his wrist. Bali offers her a gift. Lakshmi requests, "Give me that gatekeeper." Bali agrees. It is from this episode that Raksha Bandhan becomes the festival of brothers and sisters.

6(b). The Fusion of Folklore and Myth

The narrative draws upon the Vishnu Purana and the Bhagavata tradition. Kapari, however, fills it with the lively texture of Maithili vernacular speech. Expressions such as "ahar takay, pahar takay," "batjohime aankhi khiya," "talbal-talbal ladh-dular," and "halasal lahalot" enliven the tale through their idiomatic force.

"Lakshmi's manner and bearing pleased Bali greatly. His curiosity grew, and he leaned forward with eager affection and asked, 'Well, child, who are you?'"

The Maithili expression "hapasi-lapaikik," describing an affectionate movement towards someone, is particularly apt. Lakshmi's appearance as a sister is an unforced manifestation of love.

6(c). The Question of Female Power

Lakshmi is not passive in this story. She devises a plan, assumes a disguise, negotiates with Bali and secures Vishnu's release. The goddess of wealth is capable of freeing her own husband: this is a powerful narrative of female agency.

7. "Austerity and Holy Company"

7(a). Plot

Vishvamitra and Vasishtha dispute whether austerity (tapas) or the company of the virtuous (satsang) is superior. Neither Brahma nor Vishnu wishes to be drawn into the quarrel. At last Sheshanaga devises a test: the lifting of the Earth's weight. Vishvamitra offers the entire merit of his austerities but cannot raise it. Vasishtha offers "the merit of one day's satsang," and the Earth hangs suspended in the air. Austerity loses; holy company triumphs.

7(b). The Form of the Philosophical Tale

This is a philosophical fable, a tale in which an abstruse question is resolved through narrative. Tapas and satsang present a choice between individual spiritual discipline and a socially shared spiritual community.

Kapari's sense of humour remains alert. "Very well, very good. Lord Shesha told the two of them straight to their faces." The Maithili "soharde aange," meaning directly or face to face, playfully places Shesha in the role of a judge.

7(c). The Use of Vernacular Language

"Hearing this, Sage Vishvamitra was consumed with envy and exclaimed in a fit of anger: 'What! Do you think I cannot lift such a paltry weight?'"

"Ikh-bikh lagab," meaning to burn with jealousy, and "pinakale-phanaki," meaning to flare up in anger, are two invaluable Maithili idioms.

8. Didactic Tales: "Education and Initiation" and "Number"

8(a). "Education and Initiation"

In the gurukula tradition, a teacher strikes a prince without apparent cause in public just before the prince's departure. The following day he explains: "I wanted you to experience injustice. When you become king and administer justice, you must know the pain of those who suffer it."

This didactic story belongs to the Indian moral-tale tradition, yet its method of experiential learning is consistent with modern educational theory. "This opened the inner eyes of everyone present" is the tale's philosophical essence.

8(b). "Number"

A wealthy merchant loses his way at night and enters a temple. He gives money to a distressed man and also hands him his contact-number card. The man responds, "I already know the number." Astonished, the merchant asks what he means. The answer is: "God's number, which sent you to me."

With its excellent twist ending, this is a memorable didactic tale. Though no longer than a page, it carries a profound philosophical message. Its portrayal of faith in God makes it an outstanding example of Maithili moral storytelling.

9. The Tale of "Dog, Cat and Mouse"

9(a). Plot

Dog, Cat and Mouse are three friends. Dog sets out on a pilgrimage, entrusting all his documents to Cat. Cat gives them to Mouse for safekeeping. Mouse eats and uses them until they are destroyed. Dog returns to find his papers gone. Cat prepares to kill Mouse, and Mouse runs away without understanding why everyone is chasing him. "From that day to this, the dog has chased the cat, and the cat has chased the mouse whenever they meet."

9(b). The Character of an Origin Tale

This is an aetiological tale, explaining the supposed origin of a familiar phenomenon. It supplies a humorous folk answer to the question of why dogs chase cats and cats chase mice. Such narratives appear in folktale traditions throughout the world. Rudyard Kipling's Just So Stories offers a Western parallel.

9(c). The Question of Justice

The line "Mouse could not understand why everyone was chasing him" is profound. Mouse ate the paper and used it as bedding because he needed it; but the consequence was a loss for everyone. The tale concerns the consequences of an unwitting wrongdoing. From a Navya-Nyaya perspective, Mouse's "absence of knowledge" does not make his act a morally culpable offence.

10. The Tale "Gonu Babu at Home"

10(a). Plot

Gonu Jha, "the most cunning of rogues, extraordinarily quick-witted and shrewd," returns to his village after a long absence. Everyone asks, "Where have you been?" He replies, "Well, right here in the village." They are taken aback. The true reason for his absence is that during the months of Ashvin and Kartik people come round asking for contributions and favours. To avoid them, he left his home and village for those months. On returning, the refrain remains: "Well, Gonu Babu is at home."

10(b). His Place in the Gonu Jha Tradition

Gonu Jha is a distinctive folk hero of Maithili: clever, satirical and alert to his own advantage. Comparable figures in other traditions include Nasreddin Hodja in Turkish tales, Akaltam in Hebrew stories and Birbal in Hindi. Kapari keeps this narrative tradition alive.

"Well, Gonu Babu is at home" has multiple meanings: (i) literally, "I am in the village"; (ii) satirically, "I will not tell you where I went"; and (iii) implicitly, "I fled the village to escape the people who came begging." These three levels are an instance of Kuntaka's vakrokti.

10(c). Social Satire

"In these months, even the storehouse of the best-off household becomes empty." This precisely evokes the economic hardships of Ashvin and Kartik. Gonu Jha's ingenuity is a strategy for survival. It is presented humorously, yet remains grounded in reality. The episode mirrors the rural economic cycle of Maithil society.

Overall Critical Assessment

11(a). Kapari's Distinctiveness as a Storyteller

Preserving the Authentic Forms of Maithili

Kapari's most distinctive contribution is to secure literary recognition for the authentic Maithili of an alternative cultural stream. Words such as

"labkaniya," "harharahi," "chhagunae," "dhatpatae," "hapasi-lapaikik," "pachhmuriya," "hathi-bardam," "ghaihar garaju," and "hehar-thethar" might never have entered literary discourse had Kapari not written them down.

Reviving the Tradition of Animal Speech

The understanding of animal speech in "Lachhminiya Kaniya" and the divine knowledge in "The Glory of Remembering Hanuman's Name" sustain the ancient Panchatantra-Jataka tradition of Maithili folktelling. This narrative practice had almost disappeared from modern Maithili fiction.

Counter-Readings of Mythological Narratives

The questioning of Rama and Sita's relationship in "Yajna-Sita," the account of gender transformation in "Chhauri-Chhaura Sudyumna," and the questioning of Rama's maryada in "Hai Ram!" demonstrate that Kapari does not accept mythology uncritically. He enters into a critical engagement with it; herein lies his modernity.

A Skilled Use of Humour and Satire

"Gonu Babu at Home," "Number," "Austerity and Holy Company" and "God Who Dwells in the Heart" all contain humour and satire. But their humour transcends simple entertainment to become philosophical reflection and social commentary.

II(b). Limitations

(a) Length: most of the tales are extremely brief, making sustained character development impossible.

(b) Repetition: themes recur frequently, an outcome of insufficient editing.

(c) Range: the stories are largely religious, mythological or concerned with folk morality. Very few, apart from works such as "Lachhminiya Kaniya," are grounded in contemporary social reality.

II(c). Kapari's Place in the History of Maithili Folktales

Within the history of Maithili folktelling, Kapari is among the rare writers who have made rural Maithili a medium of literary narrative.

From the perspective of Videha's parallel history, these are "works excluded from mainstream history." Kapari's stories have been omitted from mainstream histories of Maithili literature. The history centred on the Sahitya Akademi had not found a place for Maithili storytellers from Nepal. Through this critique, Videha seeks to correct that injustice.

CHAPTER 02

A Critical Study of Parmeshwar Kapari's Verse

Original Poetry, Translation, Children's Songs and the Criticism of Ghazals

Introduction: Parmeshwar Kapari's Poetic World

Kapari's creative world contains several kinds of verse: his original poems; ghazals by other poets quoted in his critical writing; children's songs; a translation of the Rigveda; Maithili renderings of Sanskrit verses; and various folk songs and rhyming verses. These may be classified as follows:

(a) Original Maithili dohas and independent short poems.

(b) A Maithili translation of the Nasadiya Sukta of the Rigveda, entitled "Tattvabodh."

(c) Free Maithili renderings of Sanskrit verses from the Gita, the Nasadiya Sukta and hymns to Sita.

(d) Children's songs: "Our Janakpurdham" and "The Incarnation of Sita."

(e) The folk-song verses of "Reng–Reng."

(f) A Hindi ghazal by Dhirendra Premarshi, together with Kapari's critical response.

(g) Maithili ghazals by Dr Rajendra Vimal, accompanied by Kapari's extended criticism.

(h) The narrative poem "Dam."

1. "Tattvabodh": A Maithili Translation of the Rigveda's Nasadiya Sukta

This is the most ambitious poetic work discussed in the present study. Drawing on the Radhakrishnan–Moore volume, Kapari has translated the 129th hymn of the tenth mandala of the Rigveda, the Nasadiya Sukta, which raises some of world literature's earliest philosophical questions about the mystery of creation.

1(a). Excerpts from the Verse

There was no one then / nor even the lifeless / no air / nor was there sky above it /

What lay concealed / where? / beneath whose protection? / Was there a deep, immeasurable ocean?

There was no death then / nor was there immortal life /

It breathed in airlessness / apart from it, nothing existed here.

At the beginning desire entered it / it is thought / the very first seed of creation.

Who knows for certain? / Who will explain it clearly? / When was it born /
and when did this creation come to be?

God alone knows / and perhaps even God does not know!

1(b). The Craft of Translation

The Rigvedic original, "nāsad āsīn no sad āsīt tadānīm" ("then there was neither being nor non-being"), describes the pre-creation condition through negation. In Kapari's rendering this becomes "There was no one then / nor even the lifeless." These short, fragmented lines are signs not merely of translation but of imaginative re-creation.

For the Sanskrit "ānīd avātam svadhayā tad ekam" ("that One breathed, without air, by its own power"), Kapari writes, "It breathed in airlessness." This line offers one of Maithili's most arresting poetic paradoxes. Breathing without air expresses the ineffability of the state before creation.

1(c). An Analysis of Rasa

Among the nine rasas associated with Bharata Muni, adbhuta, the rasa arising from wonder, pervades this poem. "The very first seed of creation" marks its culmination. Yet the closing lines—"God alone knows / and perhaps even God does not know!"—transform wonder into karuna, the pathos of unknowing.

1(d). A Navya-Nyaya Perspective

According to the limits of epistemic proof considered in Gangesha Upadhyaya's theory, the four pramanas—perception, inference, comparison and testimony—cannot yield knowledge of what existed before creation. "Who knows for certain?": through this question Kapari's translation itself suggests the limits of cognition central to Navya-Nyaya.

1(e). An Analysis of Dhvani

Under Anandavardhana's theory of dhvani, this poem works at three levels: (i) the literal, a physical description of the state before creation; (ii) the metaphorical, an image of human ignorance; and (iii) the philosophical, the suggestion that "even God does not know." This is its most profound intimation of agnosticism. Philosophical verse of this order is exceedingly rare in Maithili literature.

1(f). The Videha Perspective

This bold tradition of translating Vedic philosophy is unusual in Maithili poetry. After Vidyapati, who provided a bridge between Sanskrit and Avahattha, Kapari's rendering of the Rigveda's most mysterious hymn inaugurates a new tradition. It is an important chapter in Videha's parallel history.

2. Original Dohas and Independent Short Poems

2(a). A Political Doha

> The bell has rung; politics has stirred to life. / Behold how many parties have died while still alive.

This doha is Kapari's finest expression of political satire in verse: a complete satirical portrait in two lines.

"The bell has rung" refers to the election bell; "politics has stirred to life" suggests new enthusiasm; and "died while still alive" names the moral death of political parties. The compression of these three stages into two lines demonstrates the capacity of the doha form.

Kuntaka's vakrokti appears in "died while still alive," a paradox that encapsulates the collapse of political morality in a single image. It reflects a Nepali political reality in which parties do not die merely by losing an election; they become the living dead when their moral spirit dies. This is a notable example of the modern Maithili doha.

2(b). An Aphoristic Short Poem

"The whole village is full of healers; whose path should one follow?" This two-line aphoristic poem is uttered in the context of Martyrs' Day. "The whole village is full of healers" means that everyone regards themselves as an expert; "whose path should one follow?" asks where guidance can then be found.

Kapari applies this proverb to the discourse of political movements. Nepal has countless martyrs and self-proclaimed leaders of movements, yet suffers a vacuum of genuine leadership. The metaphorical application is an example of political discourse conducted through poetry.

In terms of Bharata's Natyashastra, the lines produce hasya rasa, but comedy lies on the surface and pathos underneath. That mixture determines their aesthetic effect.

2(c). A Short Poem on Motherhood

> There is no mother like a mother. / There is no one like a mother.

In a mere six or seven words, the word "may," mother, acquires an inexhaustible significance. The poem is extremely brief, yet extraordinarily concentrated in feeling. "There is no mother like a mother" asserts an absolute uniqueness beyond comparison.

The emotional foundation is the height of parental tenderness, vatsalya. The enduring emotional condition of vatsalya, here considered within the domain of karuna in Indian poetics, is compressed into two lines. Written for Mother's Day, the poem nevertheless expresses a truth beyond any particular occasion.

2(d). A Birthday Verse

> Today, at the conclusion of Chhath; at Diwali (Lakshmi Puja), Mother's birthday; at the conclusion of Chhath, Parameshwari, Father's birthday. / Both their names accord with the days of their birth: Lakshmi on Lakshmi Puja, Parmeshwar at the breaking of the Chhath fast.

This is a son's birthday tribute to his parents, written by Kumar Bhaskar. It is not Kapari's poem but that of his son. One important poetic feature is the coincidence between the names of Lakshmi, his mother, and Parmeshwar, his father, and the festivals on which their birthdays fall. Such verse built upon coincidence has a distinctive place in the Maithili tradition.

3. Children's Songs: "Our Janakpurdham" (Our Maithili Book, Class Three) and "The Incarnation of Sita" (Bhuvaneshwar Prasad "Adhyapak," Maithili Children's Ramayana)

3(a). "Our Janakpurdham"

> The maternal uncle's home of Lava and Kusha / that is our Janakpurdham. / Daughter Sita made exemplary / this sacred land of Mithila. / This capital of Videha's King Janaka / gave birth to people of profound wisdom. / The Maithili tongue, sweet as honey / is spoken by proud Maithils.

The song is included in Our Maithili Book, Class Three. Kapari quotes it, demonstrating his awareness of literature for children.

"The maternal uncle's home of Lava and Kusha": the poetic practice of describing Janakpur as their mother's family home has a long history in Maithili. It occurs here with unaffected ease.

"The Maithili tongue, sweet as honey" is a distinctive simile. It compares the sweetness of sound with the sweetness of food, producing a transfer between sensory registers, or synaesthesia.

The rasa is vira, the heroic sentiment. The phrase "proud Maithils" appeals to self-respect and plants the seed of courage in the child's mind.

3(b). "The Incarnation of Sita" (Bhuvaneshwar Prasad "Adhyapak," Maithili Children's Ramayana)

> How did Sita take birth? / Hear the story, extensive indeed. / When the night-roaming demons wrought havoc / every righteous deed fell into ruin.
>
> No rain fell upon Mithila / so Janaka took the plough in hand. / No sooner did he begin to till the earth / than she appeared from the ground.
>
> A voice resounded through the sky: / the Mother of the World has taken birth. / Demons have multiplied upon the earth; / she will lift its heavy burden. / Mother Earth gave King Janaka / a precious new gift; / the world found deliverance / from pain, grief and suffering.

Kapari's choice to quote this children's song is apt. "The Incarnation of Sita" is an important song in the Maithili Children's Ramayana, telling in a simple and accessible rhythm the mythological narrative of Sita's birth associated with Ravana's vessel of blood.

"No sooner did he begin to till the earth / than she appeared from the ground" comprises the song's finest two lines. "Dhatibhumi," meaning to emerge from the ground, is a distinctive Maithili expression. Rhythm, rhyme and emotional significance are held in balance.

The final quatrain, opening with "A voice resounded through the sky," acquires grandeur through its longer lines. The rise and fall of the rhythm prevents the children's song from becoming monotonous.

4. The Folk Verses in "Reng–Reng"

> The swollen-throated braggarts, the chameleon people, / the leaping frogs, the carriers— / the mice have dressed for a wedding procession!
>
> Laughingstocks of the age, those who knock off their fathers' turbans, / the wanton mouse bridegroom sets out to marry— / the wedding procession has reached the cat's house!

4(a). The Character of the Folk Verse

These are song verses from the play "Reng–Reng." They belong to the distinctive Maithili tradition of phakra, a form of folk verse in which animal characters become instruments for satirising human society.

4(b). Symbolic Analysis

"Gheghaha bhemh," the swollen-throated braggart, signifies politicians engaged in self-praise; "girgit lokaniya," chameleon-like people, signifies politicians who change colours; and "kudka beng," the jumping frog, signifies opportunists. "The mice have dressed for a wedding procession"—mice going to the cat's house for a wedding—is a traditional Maithili burlesque.

"Those who knock off their fathers' turbans" refers to people who destroy their fathers' honour. "Ladho musari biyahan" evokes an unruly marriage. A wedding procession arriving at the cat's door represents the climax of comic rasa.

4(c). Links with the Folk-Theatre Tradition

In Maithili folk theatre, the natua tradition involves performers wearing animal masks to satirise society. These verses are rooted in that practice. Kapari revives this older tradition within the setting of contemporary political theatre.

5. A Hindi Ghazal by Dhirendra Premarshi: Kapari's Response as a Reader

5(a). The Ghazal

> Cultivate patience, my friend / put off needless desires, my friend. / Joy keeps company with sorrow / understand the movement of time, my friend.
>
> Whatever God has given you / preserve it, my friend. / What is gained by resentment? / drive it from your mind, my friend.
>
> Within self-forgetfulness itself / search out the self, my friend. / Immerse yourself in love / and become richly blessed, my friend.
>
> If you would become "Premarshi" / keep a heart of fire, my friend.

5(b). Kapari's Critical Perspective as Poetic Prose

The "reader's dilemma" that Kapari records after reading this ghazal is itself a piece of poetic prose. His initial reaction—"As soon as I reached the third line, the spell broke and my mind grew uneasy: ah, so this is a Hindi ghazal!"—is a natural response from someone deeply devoted to Maithili.

Kapari then acknowledges his own narrowness and examines the ghazal objectively: "Considering the language, literary elegance and overall form of the composition, one must accept that the fluency of its language and the arrangement of its ghazal structure are exceptionally graceful and pleasing." This self-correction demonstrates his integrity as a critic.

5(c). Poetic Analysis of the Ghazal

"Joy keeps company with sorrow" is a couplet associated here with the Sufi idea of fana, or annihilation of the self. Joy and sorrow are opposites, yet are companions; this paradoxical beauty belongs to the central aesthetic of Urdu ghazal.

"Within self-forgetfulness itself / search out the self" seeks khudi, the self, within bekhudi, self-loss. It is a Sufi path to self-realisation. Kapari is justified in placing Premarshi in the tradition of Mira, Kabir and Rahim.

Kapari's comparative observation—"In his work one frequently glimpses the consciousness of an age and the purity of heart associated with Mira, Tulsidas and Surdas"—is an excellent instance of Maithili literary criticism.

6. Maithili Ghazals by Dr Rajendra Vimal: Kapari's Extended Critique

6(a). Ghazal I: A Call for Revolution

> Link arm with arm; raise your voice with force. / He has stolen our bread; tear open his belly.
>
> He makes us deaf and will go on stinging us; do not worship him. / Seize him by the throat; take the sword in hand.
>
> He drank our blood; we shall make his blood flow. / Spread the blaze through every vein of your own blood.
>
> The slaying of Ravana is righteous; Lanka's sins will burn. / Beat the drums loudly and plant the banner of dharma.
>
> Even amid the clamour of words, I shall go on singing, Vimal. / Adorn and illuminate the festival of consciousness.

Critical Commentary

Kapari calls the ghazal "highly aggressive and explosive," an accurate description. "Seize him by the throat; take the sword in hand" marks the height of raudra rasa. In Bharata's poetics, anger is the enduring emotional basis of that rasa, and it appears in these lines with tremendous force.

"He has stolen our bread" voices an indictment of exploitation. "Tear open his belly" represents metaphorical revenge, not a literal prescription of violence but a poetic demand for justice. From the perspective of vakrokti,

"plant the banner of dharma" recasts resistance as a righteous war, a system of oblique symbols.

6(b). Ghazal II: "Strike Down the Hypocrite" — A Satirical Ghazal

> Bang, bang goes the gun; strike down the hypocrite. / You have given him your word; strike down the hypocrite.
>
> He will spare neither farms nor homes, daughters nor daughters-in-law; / he has revealed his true colours: strike down the hypocrite.
>
> For generations he has done nothing but cut your throat; / this is a gang of throat-cutters: strike down the hypocrite.

The refrain "Strike down the hypocrite" is repeated across the five couplets of this ghazal, intensifying raudra rasa. "Farms, homes, daughters and daughters-in-law" denotes everything that constitutes life and thus the all-consuming nature of exploitation. "Ghentkatta-toli," a gang of throat-cutters, is a distinctly Maithili term of abuse. Its use in poetry is a daring linguistic choice.

6(c). Ghazal III: "What Sort of Settlement Is This?"

> What sort of settlement is this, where everyone is wounded? / Locks are fastened to every skull, and every tongue is cut.
>
> Here people walk suspended, tied in groups to the gallows. / What sort of city is this, where people hang of their own will?
>
> The constitution changes every day, like a prostitute's new skirt; / my mother's sari remains torn even now.

This is Vimal's finest ghazal. "A settlement where everyone is wounded" is a remarkable opening couplet, or matla. "Locks upon skulls" and "tongues cut off" are metaphors of mental and verbal enslavement. The image of people moving while suspended from the gallows introduces the metaphor of crucifixion into the modern Maithili ghazal.

The simile of a constitution changing "like a prostitute's new skirt" is extremely controversial but poetically forceful. "My mother's sari remains torn even now" creates a personal yet universal image of poverty, lending Vimal's poetry its greatness.

6(d). Ghazal IV: "Only Then Is It Diwali"

> Only when all creation shines is it Diwali. / Only when the lamp of consciousness burns is it Diwali.
>
> Turn all that is old and decaying into an object of ridicule. / Only when a new lamp burns at every moment is it Diwali.
>
> Architect of darkness, beware, beware! / Only when rocket-bombs rise and battle is it Diwali.

The refrain "Only then is it Diwali" ties each couplet to a new condition for the celebration. "The lamp of consciousness" signifies intellectual awakening. "Hukkaloli," a vernacular term for open mockery, is unusual in a ghazal and brings folk language into contact with the Urdu ghazal tradition.

"Only when rocket-bombs rise and battle is it Diwali" introduces the imagery of explosions into a festival of joy and is the work's most oblique expression. The warning addressed to the "architect of darkness" is a poetic appeal to revolutionary consciousness.

6(e). Ghazal V: "Revolution in the Sky"

> Who writes revolution across the sky and leaves it hanging there? / Who dyes the earth and heavens with blood?
>
> Who slaughters the poetry of my moon and stars / and weighs a book of hatred against life?
>
> Rather than starve, people choose to die of bullets; / recognising this truth, they pick death for themselves.

The opening line, "Who writes revolution across the sky and leaves it hanging there?", is memorable in the history of the Maithili ghazal. "Dyes the earth and heavens with blood" produces an image that marks a high point in revolutionary poetry.

"The slaughter of poetry" personifies poetry as a living creature and charges someone with its murder, an unusual instance of personification in modern Maithili poetry. "Rather than starve, people choose to die of bullets" offers a brutal realism that expresses the tragedy of poverty without ornament. It is a great poetic utterance.

What Parmeshwar Kapari calls Rajendra Vimal's ghazal collection, Suryastasā Pahine ("Before Sunset"), is actually a collection of songs. Like the doha, kundaliya and rola, the ghazal is a distinct poetic form that neither Rajendra Vimal nor Dhirendra Premarshi has mastered. Now consider these so-called children's ghazals from Rajendra Vimal's collection:

> Come, good sir,
>
> Have some dates.
>
> You are the master;
>
> I am the labourer.
>
> Drunk on power,
>
> Utterly intoxicated.
>
> You are our servant;
>
> We are the ones left out.
>
> Our own rubbish heap
>
> Is what scorches us.
>
> For five long years
>
> You fill our ears with noise.
>
> You come once more;
>
> We shall seize and thrash you.
>
> The poor man's heart
>
> Will never be content.

Take a tour
In your honking car.
The ballot box
Will be riddled with holes.
Come, Mr Politician,
We shall certainly come.
This time we shall drive in
The blows of our sticks.
Come, O crow,
Come, O crow, come, come, come;
Come flying, come running;
Come, little bird, fly, fly here;
Dance and show my little child.
Come, O parrot, come, come, come;
Come, O myna, come, come, come;
Parrot and myna, fly, fly here;
Peck and drop the mangoes and fruit.
The myna arrived, grey and speckled;
The parrot arrived, bright green;
It knocked down a dark jamun fruit;
The child gathered it into a little bag.
My Grandchild
This little child of mine, my grandchild,
A radiance of joy and delight,
Will eat parathas and bread,
Will injure nobody.
So very small to look at,
But able to speak so cleverly;
Quick to play, quick to cry;
When smiling, a treasury of diamonds and pearls.
Playing digital games and with toys,
With the pieces called “touch” and “click.”

These might make good children's songs, but they are not children's ghazals.

7. Free Maithili Renderings of Sanskrit Verses

7(a). A Verse from the Gita: "Pita Hamsya Jagato" (Composition No. 86)

> "I am the father of this world, the mother, the sustainer and the grandfather; I am the object of knowledge, the sacred Om, and the Rig, Sama and Yajur Vedas. Om."
>
> Maithili rendering: "I alone am the sustainer of the entire world: the one who upholds and nourishes it and awards the fruits of every action. I am its father, mother and grandfather, the sacred Om that must be known, and the Rigveda, Samaveda and Yajurveda."

Kapari's approach to translation expands the concision of Sanskrit, which compresses a universal truth into a single verse, into an extended Maithili explanation. In rendering "dhata" as "the one who upholds and nourishes," Kapari incorporates the word's threefold meaning: creator, sustainer and dispenser of the fruits of action.

7(b). A Hymn to Sita: "Tvam Vidya Paramatrailokya Janani"

> "You are the supreme knowledge, mother of the three worlds, giver of heaven and liberation; O Goddess Sita, who draws the three worlds to herself, I bow to you."
>
> Maithili rendering: "You are supreme knowledge and the mother of all three worlds. You bestow heaven and other exalted realms. You are the centre of attraction of the three worlds. O Sita, I bow to you!"

The compact declaration "tvam vidya," "you are knowledge," becomes an elaborated statement in Maithili. The Sanskrit "trailokya-karshani," the one who attracts the three worlds, is made accessible through "the centre of attraction," a simple expression for a difficult word signifying magnetic power.

7(c). Narada's Statement: A Free Rendering of a Sanskrit Verse

> "Those who distinguish dharma from adharma, follow the Vedic path, and devote themselves to the welfare of all worlds are called holy persons." — Narada, 16 (29–31).
>
> Maithili rendering: "A person who distinguishes righteousness from unrighteousness and follows the path laid down by the Vedas is called a sadhu."

This rendering clarifies Kapari's translation philosophy. He does not translate word by word. He does not immediately expand "sarvalokahitasaktah" as "devoted to the welfare of all," because his immediate objective is to make the definition of "sadhu" intelligible to the Maithili reader.

7(d). The Gangasagar Hymn (Purana)

> "All the rivers, beginning with the Ganga, renowned throughout the three worlds, abide unfailingly in the region of Gangasagar."

> Maithili rendering: "O Parvati! All the supremely sacred rivers, beginning with the Ganga, renowned in the three worlds, dwell continuously in Mithila's Gangasagar lake!"

Kapari quotes this verse to establish the mythological importance of the Gangasagar lake in Janakpur. He translates "anapayinyo," suggesting continuous flow, as "dwell continuously." The semantic extension from "flowing" to "dwelling" is striking: the rivers do not merely flow, they inhabit a place. This is translation as imaginative creation.

8. Suresh Pandit's Hanuman Chalisa and "Dam," a Narrative Poem (Sakshi), as Presented by Parmeshwar Kapari: Extended Analysis of Verse

"Dam" (Sakshi; dedicated to the Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, 2012) is a narrative poem in a quantitative metre. Its entire plot has already been examined. Here the focus is confined to significant lines from the standpoint of poetic craft.

> There was once a Mr Lambodar, / whose belly was always empty. / He would not lift a finger to work, / but promptly emptied a heaped plate.

The rhyme between "khatte" (empty or hungry) and "turte" (immediately) is precise. "He would not kill a fly in the name of work" is the humorous idiom meaning "he would do no work at all."

> But one day, as soon as he appeared, / the king's command arrived. / The instruments of battle were prepared: / take the enemy's life!

"Sajal gel sangram-saj," "the instruments of battle were prepared," uses alliteration through repeating s and j sounds, demonstrating an awareness of metre and sound patterning.

> That same bread played its trick, / depriving him of his strength to fight. / Life slips away so easily in distress: / thus Lambodar is great!

The final line, "thus Lambodar is great," offers a satirical assertion of greatness. This irony characterises Kapari's humorous and satirical style. "Dam" is an extended poem, yet primarily narrative in character.

On Suresh Pandit's Hanuman Chalisa, Parmeshwar Kapari observes: "There are, of course, unruly, mischievous children; their literature too is full of laughter and jokes. Although Suresh Pandit's Hanuman Chalisa is somewhat older, it remains extraordinary and entertaining." Its opening lines read:

> Hail Hanuman, ocean of knowledge and virtue;
>
> Mummy laughs and Father cries.

9. Overall Assessment: Kapari's Poetic Personality

9(a). Strengths

(a) Philosophical depth: the Rigvedic translation achieves something exceptional in Maithili verse, giving poetic expression to agnosticism.

(b) Living engagement with folk-poetic traditions: the phakra and aphoristic short poems remain closely rooted in Maithili culture.

(c) Creative translation: his free renderings of Sanskrit verses into Maithili exhibit an imaginative freedom that turns translation into re-creation.

(d) The critic as poet: his remarks on Premarshi's free-form Hindi ghazal and Rajendra Vimal's song collection, published as a collection of ghazals, are themselves poetic prose.

(e) Political satire in verse: the "The bell has rung" doha is an outstanding example of the modern Maithili doha.

9(b). Limitations

(a) Very little original verse: most of the poetry under discussion is by others —Vimal, Premarshi and "Adhyapak"—and is examined by Kapari as a critic.

(b) An absence of substantial original long poems.

(c) Imagery: Kapari's images generally draw upon the folktale tradition rather than creating grand, distinctly modern images.

9(c). His Place in Videha's Parallel Literary History

Parmeshwar Kapari is primarily a storyteller and playwright and, secondarily, a critic and poet. Nevertheless, his translation of the Rigveda ("Tattvabodh"), his political dohas and the phakras of "Reng–Reng" are notable contributions to Maithili verse. Videha's parallel history, devoted to "works excluded from mainstream literary history," accords this poet, critic and translator his due recognition.

CHAPTER 03

The Creative World of Parmeshwar Kapari

Autobiographical Writing, Culture, Satire and Literary Reflection

Introduction: Parmeshwar Kapari and His Creative Universe

Kapari's more than six hundred writings—folktales, narratives, mythological stories, satire, cultural essays, discussions of language, autobiographical episodes, reflections on awards, political commentary and theatre criticism—together constitute an extensive and many-sided body of work. From the perspective of Videha's parallel literary history, Kapari belongs among the "omitted" Maithili writers who have largely been neglected by mainstream literary institutions.

1. Autobiographical and Family Episodes

1.4. "An Episode Concerning My Blessed Father"

This is one of Kapari's most moving autobiographical works. Its description of a son's final moments with his dying father exemplifies the emotional heights of Maithili prose. Expressions such as "jakhain ham potake kar ghumaeliai," "chhatpataichhai" and "barikale" draw on the language's own resources and speak directly to the heart. The father's words, "At the time of

death, such restless waves come over one," express an astonishing combination of humour and affection in the face of death. According to the idea of the ultimate resolution of pathos associated here with Abhinavagupta, the father's death brings karuna rasa to its height and leads the son to realise that "the meaning and feeling of the word 'father' cannot be sought in a dictionary!" This utterance deserves a place among the finest in Indian literature. In the "Father" episode the writer spends the period of his father's death preoccupied with his own promotion: the admission of such human frailty is a hallmark of realist literature.

6.1. "Maithili Is Highly Respected in Our Home Too"

The "Sarain" episode: Kapari calls his wife "sarain," a feminine form derived from "sar." This coinage is a distinctive instance of linguistic creativity in Maithili. "Just as the feminine of master is masterni, of doctor is doctorni, and of singh is singhni!" This simple humour reveals something of Kapari's personality. The work captures the tenderness of domestic life: "the children's mother grinding the soaked lentils for adauri while singing songs of the grinding-stone." Such an image is an incomparable record of rural life in Maithili prose.

6.2. "In Earlier Days, Women Folk ... the Lentils for Adauri"

This brief piece contrasts old and new forms of domestic life. Its comparison of a smooth, hand-shaped traditional surface with "fancy decoration" is a moving comment on cultural change. "This mother of my children, grinding the lentils for adauri and the gram flour for tisiyouri while singing at the grinding-stone!" Such an image belongs among the finest prose-poems of Maithili.

6.3. Birthday Episodes Concerning Children, Father and Grandchildren

"Even a crooked sweet made of sugar tastes sweet somehow!" This saying of Kapari's elder sister is an excellent example of folk wisdom. The proverb "what is dear from childhood is dear even in the womb," and the manner in which Kapari explains the naming of the child Prithu after King Prithu, demonstrate his sense of tradition.

2. Interpretations of Myth, Philosophy and Ritual Practice

2.2. "Definitions According to the Puranas"

Kapari presents in Maithili explanations of five concepts drawn from the Narada Smriti: truth, dharma, nonviolence, falsehood and the holy person. The inclusion of Narada's verse—"Those who discern dharma from adharma, follow the Vedic path and devote themselves to the welfare of all are called holy persons"—is appropriate. This essay attests to Kapari's learning. He is not merely a folklorist but also a student of the classical tradition. For the Videha perspective, this synthesis of learned and popular traditions is among Kapari's defining qualities.

2.3. "The Tantric Form of Goddess Chhinnamasta"

This is one of Kapari's most scholarly writings. His Tantric interpretation of Chhinnamasta through Mithila painting and its philosophical examination of creation, destruction and regeneration are exceptionally profound. "The interaction of light and sound becomes so fearsome and intense that the connection of creation with the creator is severed in a single instant." This sentence reaches the essence of Indian Tantric philosophy. "Until the umbilical cord between mother and child is cut, the newborn cannot come into an independent existence." This biological metaphor elucidates the Tantric symbolism of Chhinnamasta in a remarkable way. Kapari interprets the Tantric basis of Mithila painting from a scientific and philosophical perspective, an uncommon undertaking in Maithili literature.

2.4. "Ayurveda and Dhanteras"

The description of Brahma's creation of Ayurveda, its three foundational principles, the Atreya and Dhanvantari schools, and the churning of the Ocean of Milk testifies to Kapari's knowledge of classical traditions. His threefold classification—"Tila Sankranti is a festival of the mind," "Phagua is a festival of the mind," and "Durga Puja is of the soul"—reveals his philosophical outlook.

2.5. "Marriage Rites and Rights"

Kapari offers a learned account of the proposed derivation of "vivaha" as "vi + ava + hara" and a philosophical explanation of kanyadana, panigrahana and the sacrificial fire. His closing observation—"Ever since income and rights entered the matter, life has become a burden and a whirlpool"—offers a satirical comment on contemporary debates about marriage.

8.1. "Alha-Rudal"

The narrative in which the five Pandava brothers are reborn in the Kali age as Alha, Rudal, Brahmananda, Lakhan and the heroic Malkhan beautifully combines mythology and folk epic. Yudhishthira's unfulfilled longing—"In the Mahabharata, did I get to kill even one Kaurava?"—is fulfilled by Krishna in the Kali age. This account gives the Maithili folk-epic tradition a philosophical foundation. Placing the Alha-Rudal singing tradition within a cosmic framework of Pandava reincarnation lifts it beyond mere entertainment.

3. Language, Folk Culture and Janakpurdham

3.1. "Bharu or Moru?!"

This is an excellent example of Kapari's cultural-historical essay writing. Exploring "bharu" (Indian rupees) and "neru" (Nepali rupees), he invites a reconsideration of Maithili literary history through the tension between Nepal and India in the lives of Vidyapati and Mahendra Malangia. "Vidyapati came to Nepal, made a home, had ponds and wells dug, completed his life's work, lived and died here—and yet he remains 'bharu,' Indian?" This question touches the heart of Maithili literary nationalism. Kapari supports an

independent and self-respecting identity for Maithili in Nepal. In discussing the Guinness Book certificate episode concerning Mahendra Malangia, he poses a significant question: if Malangia is called a master of drama, is it inappropriate also to call him "a Maithili playwright of Nepal"? This is a discourse on the political identity of Nepali Maithili.

3.2. "Maithili Folk Theatre"

Kapari's essay on folk drama is an important document in the history of Maithili theatre. "Maithili culture has its various components and instruments —that is, folk language, folk dance, drama, songs and narrative ballads." This sentence articulates an integrated view of Maithili culture.

The description of the village "Parbaha" is also striking. The proposed derivation "parbah aha" carries cultural significance: one who cares for language, literature, culture and theatre is a "parbaha." This play on words illustrates Kapari's linguistic consciousness.

3.3. "Long Live the Maithili Vernacular!"

This is among Kapari's finest statements on language. "The divine speech, the language of Vedas and Puranas, religion and philosophy, arts and sciences ... had become so intricately entangled that it died": this offers a sociological explanation of the decline of Sanskrit. Kapari imagines Maithili's future as a people's language, not as "Babhan-bhasha," the Brahmin-centred standard language. The essay contains a subtle satire on Dr Ramavatar Yadav's movement for "standard Maithili": "the stiffened, affected Brahmin language." From Videha's parallel standpoint, the argument is important: Maithili must remain the people's language, rather than the exclusive domain of pandits and classical scholars.

3.4. "Sita's Companion Gangasagar"

Kapari describes the deterioration of Janakpur's Gangasagar lake through an imaginative mythological story. Gangasagar takes on "the shape of a haggard old woman" and travels to the Maha Kumbh, a striking symbolic invention. There the purity of the Ganga's waters makes her ashamed of her own condition, and she curses Janakpur's inhabitants. The satire is directed at the neglect of the city and its municipality.

6.4. "A Debate on the Development of Janakpurdham"

Kapari writes repeatedly about Mithila Movement Martyrs' Day, the dilapidated state of the Janakpur sub-metropolitan municipality, the Parbaha festival and related concerns. This is an example of social commitment. "Long live the martyrs of Mithila!" is not merely a slogan but part of Kapari's philosophy of life. He has served as convenor of the Mithila State Struggle Committee, a commitment evident throughout his writing.

Kapari's writing on the Virat Maithili Natya Kala Parishad, the Janakpurdham International Theatre Festival and the Parbaha Cultural Festival constitutes a contemporary record of Maithili theatrical history. He is not merely a spectator but an active participant and critic.

His important diagnosis of contemporary theatre is this: "Janakpur has a great many actors and actresses, but lacks the main currents of modern global theatre, theatrical philosophy, dramatic consciousness and artistic movements."

9.1. "Children's Folk Literature Overflowing with Joy and Entertainment"

Kapari underscores the importance of Maithili folk literature for children. "It is an immeasurably precious natural resource that can never become stale or exhausted": this reveals the seriousness of his engagement with children's literature. Roshan Janakpuri's grandchild's play song—"Hey, foolish one, hey, foolish one! / Why did you interrupt?"—exemplifies the rhythm and playful nonsense characteristic of Maithili children's songs, which Kapari has helped preserve.

4. Political Satire and Social Criticism

4.1. "A Janakpur Like This?"

This satire concerns the broken roads, mosquito breeding and political indifference of the Janakpur sub-metropolitan municipality. "In Ward No. 16, Pulchowk, of this great sub-metropolitan municipality, in the year 2051 … in the difficult tenure of Biltu Pajiyar … a mud road was built with much struggle … yet in the thirty years since, not a single truckload or trailer of soil has been added to it." This is an outstanding example of local journalistic prose. "Well then, Janakpur, are we to imagine the ghee of development being poured upon a leaf for the blind Surdas?" The idiom "Surdas's ghee" is a jewel of Maithili satire. The image of development's ghee, invisible to the blind, is a distinctive attack on negative politics.

4.2. A Series of Political Satires

Kapari's satirical series "Hagna-Padna," "Dhoti-Gamchha" and "Bagariya-Sanghatiya" uses invented conversations. Its attacks on Nepali politics—the Gen-Z movement, the decline of Madheshi parties, Balen Shah, Upendra Yadav and K. P. Oli—are pointed.

The multilingual texture brings Nepal's linguistic reality vividly to life. "Hey, the thing to understand is that his Kathmandu madam-wife …" This code-mixing is a significant feature of Kapari's style.

In terms of satirical rasa, Bharata's Natyashastra describes six kinds of laughter: self-directed, other-directed, mutually directed, refined, coarse and ordinary. Kapari's political satire falls within the category of laughter directed at others, exposing their foolishness and frailty. Its purpose is not merely amusement but social awakening.

4.3. "Debates Concerning the Janakpur Municipality"

Kapari's satire on the launch of two books by Rambharos Kapari "Bhramar" exemplifies his fearless critical outlook. "When you are yourself chair of the Madhesh Academy, why hold the launch at the Maithili Development Fund?" This is a direct challenge to institutional politics in Maithili literature. The

piece reveals an important part of Kapari's personality: his outspoken opposition to institutional corruption and opportunism. Arun Arya's observation that "people have lost the courage to speak the truth themselves" applies aptly to him.

5. Literary Criticism and Theatrical Thought

Kapari's critical principle is expressed in the observation: "Any work can be reviewed clearly only through impartial feeling and a generous perspective, free from infatuation or prejudice." This is the governing maxim of his critical philosophy. Such an unbiased outlook is rare in Maithili literary criticism.

7.3. The Play "Tatkal Darshan"

The publication of Dr Virendra Pandey's English review of "Tatkal Darshan," with its discussion of subject matter and technique, offers a happy example of the international recognition of Kapari's dramaturgy. Kapari attends to "the play's thematic structure and theatrical procedures, together with the arrangements required for performance." He is a practical theatre worker, not merely a theorist.

6. Conclusion

Parmeshwar Kapari's creative universe forms an invaluable chapter of Maithili literature. The living language of his folktales, the philosophical elements of mythological narratives, the fearless pen of the satirist, the poignancy of his autobiographical writing and the impartiality of his criticism all testify to the many dimensions of his talent. "MINAP is a very great movement," as Kapari himself declares, encapsulates his philosophy of life. The movement for Maithila/Mithila—its language, literature, culture and theatre—creates an integrated Mithila consciousness, and Kapari is a living representative of that consciousness.

Judged through Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti, Western literary criticism, the Navya-Nyaya epistemology of Gangesha Upadhyaya and Videha's parallel historical perspective, Kapari emerges as a significant, versatile, courageous and committed Maithili writer. It is both appropriate and necessary that he occupy a central place in Videha's parallel literary history.

CHAPTER 04

Reng–Reng: An Extended Literary Critique

The Language of Theatre, Social Satire and Dramatic Vision

1. A Biographical Introduction to the Writer Parmeshwar Kapari

1.1. Life and Career

Parmeshwar Kapari is a versatile, experimental Maithili writer, educationist and activist for Mithila and Maithili associated with Janakpurdham, Nepal, and deeply committed to social and cultural concerns. He was formerly head of the Maithili Department at the R. R. M. (Tribhuvan University) Campus, Janakpurdham. His service as a former head of the Central Department of Maithili at Tribhuvan University also made an exceptional contribution to Maithili-language teaching, literary research and the collection of folk literature.

His distinguishing characteristic is that he has simultaneously been a literary writer, an authentic scholar of folklore, convenor of the Mithila State Struggle Committee and former member-secretary of the Maithili Development Fund. In contemporary Maithili literature, he occupies a particularly significant position as an experimental and realist playwright. His writing includes folktales, drama, essays, literary criticism, social commentary and cultural debate.

1.2. Literary Genres and Published Works

Kapari's literary activity extends across several genres. His known work includes:

(a) Drama: “Reng–Reng,” a contemporary political and social satire associated with the Avantika Maithili Dramatic Institution, Janakpurdham, Nepal; (b) folktales; (c) cultural essays; (d) social commentary; and (e) folk songs and rhymes.

This range makes clear that Kapari is not simply a scholar but an imaginative and many-sided cultural practitioner. His central concerns are the vernacular language, popular society and the cultural identity of Mithila.

2. The Play “Reng–Reng”: Plot and Dramatic Craft

2.1. Introducing the Play

“Reng–Reng” is a Maithili play by Parmeshwar Kapari set around the rehearsal space of the Avantika Maithili Dramatic Institution. Its title is a sound-symbolic expression, suggesting distinctions of theatrical colour, changes in the colours of life and multilayered representations of social and political character.

Its principal characters are Shridhar, the director; Anwar; Hamal; Akshara; a boy; Lakshmi/Aishwarya; Vishnu/Vivek; Bam Bahadur; and Nunu Kaka.

Together, this group represents the social-class structure of the play: artists, workers, divine forces, police authority and the spirit of folk theatre.

2.2. An Outline of the Plot

The play opens in an old zamindari building where the Avantika dramatic troupe is rehearsing. Shridhar is engrossed in reading a poem, a song of invocation expressing the desire to become active on the stage and rebuild society.

Later, Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth, appears. This is not, however, the arrival of a divine boon but an exposure of a bitter truth: where wealth actually resides in society and how a corrupt system of government appropriates it. The central assertion of the play is that poverty is the root of every evil.

Vishnu then appears, but even he cannot distribute Lakshmi's gold. Bam Bahadur, the policeman, enters and arrests the artists. Finally Nunu Kaka, the symbol of folk tradition, appears and reveals the truth through folk theatre. The play ends with a marriage ceremony symbolising renewal and new life.

2.3. Dramatic Form and Technique

"Reng–Reng" is written in the manner of epic theatre. Changes of vocal register, movement between absorption and political sloganeering, dance and song bring it close to Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt, or alienation effect. Five major theatrical techniques are employed:

(1) Changes in vocal delivery as an alienation effect.

(2) Colour and wave: the metaphorical representation of scene changes.

(3) Episodic construction through fragmented scenes.

(4) Rhythmic variation through folk song, humri and the style of political slogans.

(5) Metatheatre: the play's self-referential concern with a play inside a play.

3. A Fourfold Method of Analysis

According to Videha's parallel literary-historical perspective, the four pillars of criticism are: (i) Indian aesthetics of rasa, dhvani and vakrokti; (ii) Western critical theory; (iii) the Navya-Nyaya of Gangesha Upadhyaya; and (iv) Videha's parallel historical approach.

3.1. Indian Aesthetics: Rasa, Dhvani and Vakrokti

3.1.1. Rasa: The Dominant Aesthetic Emotions of the Play

In the light of Bharata's Natyashastra, with its nine rasas in drama, and Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati, which theorises aesthetic relish, the rasas of "Reng–Reng" may be examined as follows.

Principal rasa: karuna, or pathos.

The tragedy of poverty, the suffering of unemployed artists and Lakshmi's departure empty-handed establish the enduring emotional basis of karuna

rasa throughout the play. The lament "poverty is a disease" sustains its atmosphere of suffering and compassion.

Satirical rasa (hasya and raudra): a double aesthetic experience.

The playwright creates a remarkable tension between Bharata's comic and furious rasas. In the entrance of the policeman Bam Bahadur and Lakshmi's departure, laughter and anger mingle. In terms of Abhinavagupta's idea of rasabhasa, what emerges is not the complete flowering of a rasa but an incomplete, disturbed aesthetic experience. Such moments recur throughout "Reng–Reng."

Vira rasa: resistance at the conclusion.

Anwar and Vivek's fearless resistance in the prison scene and the disclosure of truth through folk theatre express the heroic rasa. The proclamation "Om kham brahman—suga ritasya pantha" marks its culmination.

3.1.2. The Theory of Dhvani: Anandavardhana's Perspective

According to Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (c. 850 CE), the distinguishing feature of outstanding literature is dhvani: the meaning suggested beyond what the words directly denote. Three levels of suggestion can be recognised in "Reng–Reng."

At the first, literal level, "Reng–Reng" evokes the sound of colour. At the second, metaphorical level, it signifies the changing colours of life. At the third, political level, it evokes the fragmentation of popular culture under corrupt government.

The title itself is a richly resonant sign in which rang (colour and the stage), rog (disease as poverty), ran (struggle) and reng (the sound of a stifled cry) echo simultaneously.

3.1.3. Vakrokti: Kuntaka's Perspective

According to Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (tenth century), excellent literature and drama depend upon vakrokti: a distinctive, oblique expression that departs from straightforward statement. "Reng–Reng" provides several examples:

(a) Vishnu's entrance is not divine but satirical; he speaks only "a couple of words" and departs.

(b) Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth, leaves empty-handed: the work's most strikingly oblique statement.

(c) The recitation of the Satyanarayana Puja is a religious ceremony rendered satirical by the surrounding poverty.

(d) Gold coins signify dreams of wealth that are reduced to ashes: an oblique symbolic system.

3.2. Western Critical Theories

3.2.1. Brechtian Epic Theatre

Bertolt Brecht's (1898–1956) theory of epic theatre offers the closest Western parallel to "Reng–Reng." The Brechtian Verfremdungseffekt, or alienation effect, operates here in the following ways:

(a) Shifts of vocal delivery and songs and dances within the play interrupt emotional identification and encourage the audience to think critically. These effects approximate Brechtian Gestus. (b) The slogan-like repetition of "poverty is a disease" recalls Brecht's use of song. (c) Anwar and Akshara's entanglement over a mobile phone in the prison scene connects spectators with lived reality.

3.2.2. Marxist Dramatic Criticism

The class struggle of "Reng–Reng" may be considered in the light of Raymond Williams's Drama from Ibsen to Brecht (1952) and Terry Eagleton's Marxism and Literary Criticism (1976).

Three social groups constitute the dramatic conflict: the ruling class (police, government and Vishnu as the divinity of the status quo); the artistic class (Shridhar, Anwar, Hamal and Akshara, all unemployed artists); and the popular class (Nunu Kaka and the boy). This triangular conflict is a dramatic transformation of Marxist class struggle. The accumulation, distribution and ultimately dispiriting disappearance of gold, or capital, is a metaphor for capitalist accumulation.

3.2.3. A Postcolonial Perspective

In the light of Homi Bhabha's The Location of Culture (1994) and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988):

The linguistic debate in "Reng–Reng"—Maithili versus Nepali, Hindi, English, Sanskrit and Urdu, and the dispute about which language should appear on Vishnu's gold coin—is a remarkable scene of postcolonial hybridity. The playwright creates what Bhabha calls a "Third Space," where no single language or culture holds unquestioned supremacy. The entrance of Nunu Kaka, embodying the spirit of folk theatre, challenges colonial and Brahminical-Sanskritic dominance through the argument for theatre as Bharata Muni's "fifth Veda."

3.2.4. Feminist Criticism

Akshara's character may be examined in the light of Judith Butler's Gender Trouble (1990) and Simone de Beauvoir's The Second Sex (1949).

Akshara is the sole female character who speaks boldly and fearlessly in the play. She proposes a love marriage to Hamal, the male protagonist, and speaks to the police without fear. In the Lakshmi episode, however, a tension between women's economic power, embodied in the goddess of wealth, and patriarchal economic authority becomes visible as a form of performativity in Butler's sense.

3.2.5. Chinese Literary Theory

The Chinese theory of jingjie, the aesthetic realm or realm of experience, associated with Wang Guowei's Renjian Cihua (1908–1910), and the tradition of feng, or satire in Chinese theatre, offer further points of comparison.

The political satire of "Reng–Reng" can be compared with the satirical features of Chinese zaju, the musical drama of the Yuan dynasty, and Kunqu opera. Mocking humour directed at ruling-class folly, stories nested within stories and the poetic use of folk melodies are central to those traditions. An awareness of poverty (pinkun yishi) and the desire for social justice form a common concern.

3.3. Navya-Nyaya: The Epistemology of Gangesha Upadhyaya

3.3.1. Direct Perception and Dramatic Truth

The epistemology of "Reng–Reng" may be read through the theory of pratyaksha, direct perception, in the perception section of Gangesha Upadhyaya's thirteenth-century Mithila treatise Tattvachintamani.

The immediate experience of poverty—Anwar's declaration "We are dying of hunger"—is presented as nirvikalpaka pratyaksha, indeterminate perception. The manifestation of Lakshmi and the shower of gold constitute savikalpaka pratyaksha, determinate perception, which ultimately proves illusory. This is a dramatic realisation of the problem of perceptual illusion in Gangesha's theory.

3.3.2. Inference and the Logical Sequence of the Play

Gangesha's vyaptigraha, the apprehension of invariable concomitance that makes inference possible, is treated as the basis of the play's central reasoning:

Vyapti: "Where poverty persists, every disease persists"—this is the play's hetu, or logical reason. Sadhya: "Poverty is the cause of every disease"—this is presented as its paksha, or subject of inference.

Through the Navya-Nyaya technique of paramarsha, subsumptive reflection, the playwright turns Shridhar's speech into a philosophical and logical declaration.

3.3.3. Verbal Testimony and the Language Dispute

An important scene questions the language to be inscribed on a gold coin: Maithili, Nepali, Hindi, English, Sanskrit or Urdu? The episode is a theatrical test of Gangesha's theory of shabda-pramana, testimonial knowledge. Under that theory, testimony is valid only when the speaker is apta, or trustworthy. The conflict over linguistic power thus asks which language can speak with authority, and who qualifies as an authoritative speaker.

3.4. The Videha Parallel-History Perspective

3.4.1. The Counter-Canon and Parmeshwar Kapari

The central argument of the Videha parallel literary-history movement is that much has been omitted from mainstream histories of Maithili literature

centred on the Sahitya Akademi in New Delhi and Nepal's academies, particularly the work of Nepali Maithili writers, marginal authors and folk-theatre traditions.

Parmeshwar Kapari represents this omitted group. His play "Reng–Reng":

(a) Represents the Maithili theatre centred on Janakpurdham, Nepal.

(b) Makes the institutional dominance of the Sahitya Akademi a direct object of satire.

(c) Places folk theatre, particularly in the Nunu Kaka episode, on an equal footing with classical drama.

(d) Centres the struggles of unemployed artists, largely absent from mainstream literary history.

3.4.2. "Reng–Reng" in a Parallel History of Maithili Theatre

"Reng–Reng" occupies a distinctive place in Maithili dramatic history. Ayodhyanath Choudhary's response indicates that the play accurately represents the truth of its age, popular realities and a political atmosphere informed by the Gen-Z movement, the rebellious mobilisation of a younger generation.

4. Comparative Study with Other Maithili Playwrights and Writers

Where the mainstream has been absorbed in historical subjects and cultural revival, Kapari concentrates on contemporary political reality. Mainstream dramatic technique follows the classical three unities of place, time and action more closely; "Reng–Reng," in contrast, adopts the open structure of epic theatre.

Comparison with Mahendra Malangia

Where Mahendra Malangia succeeded in raising folk theatre primarily onto an aesthetic plane, Kapari transforms it into an instrument of political resistance. Both playwrights make satire a primary literary device in Maithili drama, Malangia in a more limited way and Kapari in an open dramatic form. Their concerns also differ. Malangia addresses the problems of a more restricted social class, while Kapari, like Bechan Thakur, writes about unemployment, against corrupt systems and in defence of Maithili identity.

The character of Shridhar, the director, may be a satirical allusion to Nepal's institutional Maithili literary establishment.

The Nunu Kaka episode echoes the dramatic tradition of Jyotirishwar's Dhurta Samagama and Vidyapati's Gorakshavijaya (the latter Vidyapati being distinguished from the earlier one preceding Jyotirishwar). The references to Bharata Muni's Natyashastra and to drama as the "fifth Veda" are directly related to this tradition. Kapari restores it to a contemporary political setting.

5. Critical Assessment: Strengths and Limitations

5.1. The Play's Distinctive Strengths

(a) A successful synthesis of folk-theatre tradition and modern political theatre.

The most important achievement of "Reng–Reng" is its transformation of Maithili folk-theatre phakras into instruments of contemporary political drama. In one respect it goes beyond Brecht's epic theatre, for its aesthetic roots lie in local folk traditions.

(b) Linguistic plurality and cultural dialogue.

The presence of Maithili, Nepali, Hindi, Sanskrit, Urdu and English forms a multilingual ensemble that itself amounts to a cultural and political statement. The identity of Maithili in Nepal, a multilingual region, is experienced vividly in the play.

(c) Metatheatre: a play within a play.

"Reng–Reng" is a metatheatrical work: the story of rehearsals by a dramatic institution becomes itself a social drama. This play-within-a-play structure is uncommon in Maithili theatre.

(d) The Aishwarya/Lakshmi episode as an economic metaphor.

The goddess's shower of gold, its appropriation by greedy characters and her eventual empty-handed departure form a striking metaphorical portrayal of capitalist economic relations, satisfying the principal demands of a Marxist critical reading.

5.2. Limitations and Points of Criticism

(a) The closing marriage scene, the wedding of Hamal and Akshara, seems somewhat inconsistent with the play's political intensity. This resolution suggests a compromise with commercial theatrical conventions.

(b) Nunu Kaka's argument concerning the "fifth Veda," which marks the drama's philosophical height, could have received greater development.

(c) Psychological depth is unevenly distributed among the characters. Shridhar and Anwar are well developed, but the boy and Bam Bahadur occasionally become oversimplified stereotypes.

6. The Literary Significance of the Play and Playwright

6.1. Contribution to Maithili Theatre

"Reng–Reng" opens a new dimension in the theatre of Maithili-speaking Nepal. It demonstrates that:

(a) Maithili drama can be situated in the context of world-class political theatre.

(b) Folk theatre is not a primitive form but a medium for thoroughly modern thought.

(c) The struggles of unemployed and marginalised Maithili artists are serious literary subjects.

(d) Janakpurdham, a centre of Maithili theatre in Nepal, possesses its own dramatic tradition independently of histories centred on Darbhanga.

6.2. His Place in Videha's Parallel History

From the perspective of Videha's parallel literary movement, Parmeshwar Kapari is a writer who:

(a) Continues his literary work outside dominant institutional systems; (b) connects folk-literary traditions with contemporary political theatre; (c) gives literary expression to the struggle for Maithili identity in Nepal; and (d) integrates Mithila's cultural richness with modern intellectual concerns.

All these characteristics exemplify the Videha parallel history's subtitle, "Works Excluded from Mainstream History."

7. Conclusion

Parmeshwar Kapari's "Reng–Reng" is a Maithili play that presents life as though on a stage. Poverty, corruption and the unemployment of artists are all maladies. Yet the playwright is no pessimist. Through folk theatre, the power of the fifth Veda and the symbol of a new marriage, he seeks to communicate an indomitable hope.

Viewed through the four traditions of Indian rasa-dhvani-vakrokti aesthetics, Western epic theatre, Chinese satirical drama and Gangesha's Navya-Nyaya epistemology, "Reng–Reng" is a rich, multilayered work that adds a new dimension to the Maithili theatrical tradition.

In Videha's parallel literary history, Kapari emerges as an important playwright marginalised by mainstream literary historiography, whose "Reng–Reng" holds an unforgettable place in the history of Maithili theatre.

CHAPTER 05

Gahan Ugras: A Multidimensional Dramaturgical Critique

Society, Conflict and a Multilayered Analysis of Theatre

Historical Background and Publication of "Gahan Ugras"

In the field of contemporary Maithili drama and theatrical experimentation, Parmeshwar Kapari's "Gahan Ugras" is a historical landmark. The first edition was published by Prithu Prakashan,

Janakpurdham, in Phagun 2073 of the Bikram Sambat calendar. Written as a wholly original dramatic work, the book features a cover painting by the distinguished Mithila artist S. C. Suman, with typesetting and design by Kumar Bhaskar. Kapari dedicated this remarkable play to Kunalji, the renowned historical theatre practitioner whose dramatic creativity and work on the stage have brought lasting distinction to the Maithili language and literature.

The distinguished scholar of Nepali theatre Dr Abhi Subedi describes the structure as "experimental," observing that instead of conventional scene arrangements or artificial scenography, Kapari constructs the stage through human dialogue and the internal relations created by speech. The central character is a landlord, or jimdar, around whom social bonds are continuously made and broken. Kapari is known for confronting entrenched systems. He is himself a living dictionary of Maithili, as the rich and authentic vocabulary of "Gahan Ugras" abundantly demonstrates.

Historically, Janakpurdham has been the theatrical and cultural capital of the Mithila region within Nepal. Its vitality derived especially from the Mithila Natya Kala Parishad (MINAP), established in 1979, whose energy sustained a consciousness of Maithili drama. Towards the end of the twentieth century, however, the premature death of Dhirendra Dhumketu contributed to a decline in Janakpur theatre. At around the same time, theatre in Patna, India, also suffered inactivity; obscene orchestras came to dominate traditional village stages; and people who turned Vidyapati festivals into businesses of fundraising and subscriptions began to stigmatise deserving cultural workers rather than honouring them with the ceremonial pag. Mahendra Malangia's slapstick humour continued to ridicule the proletariat. Amid this deep darkness, the efforts of organisations such as MINAP, Akriti, Achhinjal and Bhangima brought a revival of Maithili drama in Janakpur. It was at this time, inspired by the realities of Nepal's ten-year Maoist people's war and the devastation surrounding the Second People's Movement, that Ramesh Ranjan appeared with the play "Sakhi" and Parmeshwar Kapari with "Gahan Ugras."

Thematic Structure, Symbolic Design and Sociopolitical Reality

The plot of "Gahan Ugras" is principally divided into two parts, which metaphorically present the historical discourse of Nepal's feudal transition, the social effects of the people's war and cultural colonisation. Its initial period concerns the political crisis of reaction following Nepal's Second People's Movement of Bikram Sambat 2062–63. The repression of the monarchy and the autocratic Panchayat system is weakening, but Gyanendra's government is making its last determined attempt to retain power by force; meanwhile, a new movement for a federal republic through a constituent assembly is spreading across the country.

A Close Analysis of Part One

Part One begins in the crumbling and dilapidated home of Phulgen Singh, a Rajput landlord who represents the remnants of feudalism. Not a grain remains in any of his granaries. The landlord's children live away from home, and a Dhanuk villager serving as his manager attends to him and prepares his meals. The irascible old landlord, Phulgen Singh, sits with a gamchha wrapped about his knees and back, swatting flies while remembering his former feudal prestige. The village's insolent and mischievous children, Tunma and Musna, sing traditional mocking songs in his veranda: "An elephant comes, a horse comes; at this old fellow's wedding, his grandson will go!" and "Reng, reng, reng, there's a frog upon your plate!" Two girls perform the Jat-Jatin game and expose the landlord's exploitative nature by singing, "This landlord is the master of the village, isn't he? His weighing scales are crooked and his seer is short, isn't it?"

At this point a middle-aged woman named Sati enters. She tells them to stop hurling abuse at the landlord and warns him that the age of feudal oppression has ended and that blows and kicks are now inevitable. Five revolutionary young people then appear on stage:

Phulo Khatbe: a combative Dalit human-rights activist.

Dukhiya Sada: the voice of the oppressed, appearing as a representative of Amnesty International.

Subhadra Mandal: an active political worker.

Jwala Prasad Singh (Jwala): an underground fighter in the Maoist people's war who has taken up arms to end exploitation.

Vidyapati Yadav: an outspoken journalist and communications worker who exposes the exploiting classes through the force of his pen.

The landlord boasts of his old feudal exploitation: "Your fathers and grandfathers used to graze cattle at our mansion, and your wives served as the mansion's maidservants." Enraged, the Maoist fighter Jwala Singh kicks him, and the old landlord falls trembling to the ground. The young activists leave to attend and report on a major political rally against reactionary forces. Shortly afterwards a servant runs in and, weeping, tells the old man Khokhna and the old woman that the police fired indiscriminately at the rally held at the school. Sati was struck twice in the chest and died; Jwala Singh died immediately; Phulo is taking her last breaths; and Subhadra and Vidyapati are in critical condition.

Part Two: Metaphorical and Cultural Discourse

Part Two begins as a surreal and allegorical journey. Baba Abhelba and his paralysed disciple Baklelba, who trembles as he walks as though pounding rice, travel towards Janakpurdham carrying a gourd vessel, a water pot and a blanket, singing the devotional refrain "Latak satak Siyarama." Even after the bundle falls from his head, the disciple continues singing jogira. On reaching Janakpurdham, people who have gathered to sleep there—Lakhna, Bechna,

Mangla and Janka—assemble around them. Janka, the boatman, recounts the marriage of Rama and Sita during the festival of Vivaha Panchami. According to his telling, after the wedding Dasharatha obstinately demanded a dowry, whereupon Janaka placed his own head before Dasharatha. The narrative becomes a metaphor for Mithila's unending cultural exploitation.

Meanwhile, Genma and Phaguni hear the Earth weeping. When everyone digs into the soil, they find a thick stream of bright-red blood. Vidyapati explains that it is the blood shed in the oppression carried out 230–240 years earlier by the Gorkha kings of the Shah dynasty. Beneath the soil lie the remnants of Maithili language, culture and art, destroyed by the repressive policy of "one language, one dress." At Bulanti and Dukhiya's appeal, the women sing songs of rebirth: Chhath songs, Chaitavar and Jat-Jatin. Finally Vidyapati leads a great revolutionary procession calling for the release of Maithili from its eclipse—its "gahan ugras"—and for the creation of an autonomous Mithila province in a new federal Nepal.

1. General Introduction to the Book and Its Structure

Parmeshwar Kapari's Maithili play "Gahan Ugras," a vernacular transformation of the expression "grahan ugras," or release from an eclipse, is an outpouring of intense social suffering. It was published by Prithu Prakashan, Janakpurdham, in Phagun 2073. Divided into Part One and Part Two, the play constructs its narrative around the sociopolitical circumstances of the Mithila region of Nepal. Its many characters represent different social classes: landlord Phulgen Singh (the exploiting feudal lord); Tunma and Musna (comic child characters); Girl One and Girl Two (rebellious female voices); Phekua (a young man); the Heroine (a symbol of new cultural distortion); Bulanti, Suvansh, Subhadra, Jwala, Dukhiya, Phulo and Sati (members of the proletarian populace); an old man and an old woman; Vidyapati (a symbolic embodiment of cultural consciousness); Janka, Bechna and Lakhna (representing various sections of Mithila society); and the Telephone Man (symbolising modern communications). The breadth of the cast itself demonstrates that the playwright did not wish to exclude any social group from the stage.

2. From the Perspective of Indian Dramaturgy

Indian Dramatic Theory and the "Theatre of Roots"

The theory of rasa in Indian dramaturgy, particularly karuna, vira and raudra, thoroughly animates "Gahan Ugras." Suresh Awasthi's "Theatre of Roots" movement sought to revive indigenous folk forms in opposition to colonial Western realist theatre. Habib Tanvir, Ratan Thiyam, B. V. Karanth and K. N. Panikkar connected folk ritual and indigenous performance traditions with modern political consciousness.

In "Gahan Ugras," Kapari gives a new expression to this philosophy of roots within the Maithili theatre movement. Traditional Maithili dance-drama forms, including Jat-Jatin, Jhijhiya and folk songs, had generally been regarded as mere entertainment, often without written scripts. Rambharos

Kapari "Bhramar" and Parmeshwar Kapari, however, transform such folk performances into powerful political weapons against class exploitation and colonial oppression. When Jat-Jatin songs are heard in Part Two, their dialogues express the painful reality of migrant life. This is the revitalisation of folk tradition as a living, dynamic practice—the central principle of the Theatre of Roots.

2(a). The Five Junctures and the Structure of the Plot

Bharata Muni's Natyashastra divides a dramatic plot into five junctures: mukha, pratimukha, garbha, vimarsha and nirvahana. Within this framework, the mukha, or opening, is the scene in the landlord's courtyard, where the granaries are empty and Tunma and Musna sing mocking songs. The pratimukha emerges as a wave of popular protest begins challenging the landlord's authority. In the garbha, the appearance of the Heroine raises questions of cultural disintegration and economic migration. The vimarsha comes when the proletarian collective, in Vidyapati's symbolic presence, seeks a path to liberation. The nirvahana, the moment of resolution, is not clearly present. This is a significant dramaturgical weakness.

2(b). Rasa

The Natyashastra proposes eight or nine rasas. In "Gahan Ugras," karuna predominates in the lament of the elderly couple, in women's songs about departure to foreign lands and in Bulanti's grief for her only son. Vira rasa emerges in the popular movement of the second part. Bibhatsa, disgust, is evoked in the accounts of the landlord's exploitation. Hasya rasa appears in the childlike, mocking exchanges between Tunma and Musna. Shringara, however—regarded by Bharata as the king of the rasas—is almost entirely absent. From the standpoint of the theory of rasa-dhvani associated with the commentator Abhinavagupta, the language of the play has a rich capacity for suggestion, though its dhvani does not fully develop because the writing lacks sufficient literary refinement.

2(c). Types of Hero and Classification of Characters

The Natyashastra identifies four kinds of hero: dhirodatta, dhiroddhata, dhiralalita and dhiraprasanta. "Gahan Ugras" has no single central hero. Vidyapati symbolically occupies the position of the calm, composed dhiraprasanta hero, calling forth cultural awareness. The people collectively become the protagonist, a conception more consistent with the Indian folk-theatre tradition than with classical Sanskrit drama. This may be understood as a deliberate dramaturgical choice.

2(d). Number of Acts and Dramatic Form

The Natyashastra describes the ten dramatic forms, or dasharupakas, including nataka, prakarana, bhana, vyayoga and samavakara. "Gahan Ugras" differs from the conventional attributes of classical nataka and comes closer to prakarana because it portrays actual social life rather than a royal plot. In the context of folk performance, however, it is more closely connected with Vidapat Nach, Jat-Jatin and the collective singing traditions of Sama-

Chakeva. Female characters appearing on stage with headcloths tied and singing cultural songs sustain a living continuity with Mithila's folk-theatre traditions.

3. From the Perspective of Western Dramaturgy

Comparative Reflections on Western and Chinese Dramatic Theory

Bertolt Brecht's epic theatre and Verfremdungseffekt, or alienation effect, withhold emotional absorption in the plot to provide spectators with an opportunity for rational scrutiny. Brecht's theory was influenced by traditional Chinese performance, particularly the acting of Mei Lanfang. In Chinese theatre the fourth wall is broken to permit direct communication with spectators.

Huang Zuolin, a pioneer of Chinese spoken drama, or huaju, articulated this method in his conception of xieyi, or essentialist theatre, whose leading qualities are fluidity, flexibility, sculpturality and conventionality.

The dramatic form of "Gahan Ugras" is a Maithili adaptation of xieyi and Brechtian principles. According to Dr Abhi Subedi, dialogue and relationships between characters create the stage in place of realistic scenography. Scene changes are exceptionally fluid and flexible: without the fall of a curtain, the action moves directly from the present to the repression at Simraungarh and historical displacement 240 years earlier. Baklelba's trembling gait and the landlord's way of sitting wrapped around his staff illustrate symbolic conventionality.

A Comparison with Yiddish Dramatic Theory and the Discourse of Displacement

Yiddish theatre developed in the Yiddish language of Ashkenazi Jews in Eastern Europe. Its roots lay in the Purimshpils, comic performances held during Purim that sharply attacked contemporary social absurdities and wealthy classes. The satirical performances at Maithili's Vivaha Panchami tableaux and MINAP's "Grand Fools' Conference" are close to the realistic and comic style of the Purimshpils.

In Yiddish theatre, the Broder Singers were itinerant performers who changed costumes and presented comic, satirical sketches; Abraham Goldfaden built the foundations of professional Yiddish theatre out of this performance culture. The children's farce at the door of landlord Phulgen Singh in the opening of "Gahan Ugras," and the comic exchanges between Baba Abhelba and his disciple Baklelba in Part Two, resemble the indigenous, humorous performance methods of the Broder Singers.

In examining the struggle between shund, or popular "trash" theatre, and literary theatre in the Yiddish tradition, Itsik Manger argued that shund represented an "open stage" without academic acting, where popular desire could find unrestricted expression. The Maithili theatre movement has similarly experienced conflict between popular forms—folk dances and

kirtaniya performance—and refined literary theatre. "Gahan Ugras" bridges this divide by connecting folk culture with political liberation.

Displacement, Overseas Employment and the Wounds of Nostalgia

Diaspora, migration and nostalgia have provided central foundations for Yiddish theatre. Poor Jews who migrated from Eastern Europe to America recalled their shtetls, or Jewish villages, through plays and songs such as "Mein Shtetl Belz," seeking relief from their sorrows.

"Gahan Ugras" presents this tragedy of modern Maithil displacement with considerable force. The dialogue conducted through a public call office between a Maithil migrant worker, Mundha, trapped in the oppressive kafala system of the Gulf states, including Qatar and Saudi Arabia, and the "Gulf widow," the Heroine, living alone at home, may be seen as a Maithili adaptation of Yiddish theatrical reflections on displacement. Fears concerning AIDS, the use of condoms and suspicions of infidelity reveal the harsh realities of migrant life and the wounds of nostalgia.

3(a). Aristotle's Theory of Mimesis and the Three Unities

In his Poetics, Aristotle explains tragedy through imitation and its production of catharsis, or the purification of the spectator's emotions. "Gahan Ugras" does not closely follow the three unities of time, place and action: its settings move among the village, a public call office or police post, fairgrounds, the Judshital bathing place and other locations, while its timescale appears to extend across years. Its strongest Aristotelian element, unity of action, is nevertheless partly present, because every episode circles around the common struggle between oppression and liberation.

In terms of Aristotle's theory of tragedy, peripeteia, or reversal of fortune, appears in the landlord's fall: once all-powerful, he is finally chased away by children calling, "Set the dog upon him; send the cat running after him." Anagnorisis, or recognition, however, is conspicuously absent, preventing the play from achieving the full structure of classical tragedy.

3(b). Brechtian Influence: Theatre of Distanciation

The most evident influence on "Gahan Ugras" is the German playwright's anti-illusionist dramatic method. Dr Abhi Subedi's introduction explicitly describes the play as experimental, remarking that "human beings themselves are the creators of the stage setting and scenography, and it is they who fashion the dramatic body of 'Gahan Ugras'." In keeping with Brechtian epic theatre, the narrative thread repeatedly breaks, characters sing popular songs that dissolve theatrical illusion, and spectators are encouraged to respond intellectually instead of identifying emotionally with the action.

Tunma and Musna's humorous song—"An elephant comes, a horse comes; at this old fellow's wedding, his grandson will go"—is a distinctly Brechtian intervention, forcing spectators to see the grotesque features of reality with critical awareness.

3(c). Stanislavski's Psychological Realism

Judged by Stanislavski's emphasis on discovering the inward lives of characters, "Gahan Ugras" offers comparatively little psychological depth. Bulanti's suffering at the loss of her son and the Heroine's conflict over her double life offer some moments of dramatic sensitivity, but characterisation remains incomplete overall. The playwright has evidently given priority to social purpose over the individual development of characters.

3(d). Existentialist Drama

In terms of the existentialist outlook of Camus and Sartre, an echo can be heard in the play's underlying grief: people remain alive, but the system strips life of meaning. Bulanti's cry that her son has left home and that she has not seen his face expresses the existential pain of a disjointed life without any apparent guiding destiny.

4. From the Perspective of Israeli Dramatic Thought

Hanoch Levin (1943–1999), a central figure of modern Israeli theatre, excelled at dramatising political satire and the suffering of ordinary people. "Gahan Ugras" resembles Levin's bitter directness in its mocking exchanges against the landlord, its use of children's voices to ridicule authority and its collective songs of protest. Just as the anguished speech of ordinary citizens becomes theatrical language in Israeli drama, Kapari undertakes a comparable task rooted in the soil and waters of Mithila. Yet "Gahan Ugras" does not fully attain the philosophical density characteristic of the Israeli theatrical tradition.

5. From the Perspective of Chinese Theatrical Traditions

Chinese theatre, especially Yuan opera and political theatre after the Mao era, is characterised by the integration of song, dance and dialogue to voice collective consciousness. The recurring folk songs in "Gahan Ugras"—Judshital songs, Holi songs, songs associated with the ceremonial turban and voices opposing dowry—function comparably. Presenting Vidyapati, a historical and cultural symbol of Mithila, as a dramatic character also recalls the Chinese theatrical practice of using historical and mythic figures to carry contemporary political messages.

6. The Play's Principal Distinguishing Features

First, political candour: the play brings Nepal's monarchy, the Maoist people's war, the Second People's Movement, Gyanendra's reactionary rule and the establishment of the federal democratic republic directly onto the stage. It is thus an explicit political testimony. The Indian part of Mithila, now outside this political history, encounters it through the play: theatrical literature is being created in a distinctive geographical and cultural situation.

Second, linguistic stratification: the landlord's language differs markedly from that of the workers, just as the women's speech differs in tone from the men's. Vidyapati speaks in an elevated literary and exhortatory register. Through the Telephone Man, the playwright satirises modern

communication culture. This stratified linguistic structure marks Kapari as a mature dramatist.

Third, the importance of women's voices: Girl One and Girl Two openly curse and chase the landlord, singing, "Put jaggery in this old fellow's pan; set the dog upon him; send the cat after him." Bulanti and Subhadra also voice resistance. The strong presence of women challenges Mithila's patriarchal social order through theatrical language.

Fourth, the inclusion of cultural rituals: the sprinkling of water at Judshital, the celebration of Holi, folk songs and the tying of a ceremonial turban are woven naturally into the plot. They raise "Gahan Ugras" beyond an exclusively political play and make it a record of cultural memory.

Fifth, criticism of dowry: in one important scene, Lakhna, Janka and Bechna jointly expose the custom of dowry through satire. "Understand this: it was from the time of King Janaka, among our own people, that the dowry system began." The dialogue reveals a satirical perspective that links King Janaka's cultural prestige to a social evil.

7. Principal Limitations of the Play

First, the looseness of the plot: the sequence of events does not have a tightly ordered structure. One scene often follows another through coincidence rather than causation. Neither the sutradhara convention associated with Bharata nor Brecht's clear division of scenes supplies a coherent organising device. Readers and spectators must themselves connect the narrative strands.

Second, incomplete character development: the symbolic presence of Vidyapati is ambitious, but its dramatic possibilities have not been fully realised. The Heroine is made a symbol of cultural corruption without sufficiently exploring its underlying social and economic causes. The landlord remains a one-dimensional exploiter without human complexity.

Third, ambiguity of the ending: the final scene brings together processions, slogans and agitation without a clear dramatic outcome. "Release the eclipse that has fallen upon society and culture" gives the play's title its meaning, but this is a poetic rather than a dramatic conclusion. The absence both of the nirvahana juncture expected in Indian dramaturgy and of the denouement expected in Western dramatic theory constitutes a creative limitation.

Fourth, the complexities of staging: numerous locations, a large cast, performances of folk music and the distant sounds of popular protest are difficult, though not impossible, to stage with the limited resources available to many theatres in Mithila.

Dr Abhi Subedi writes in his introduction: "The play will meet the director's test one hundred per cent, and that of the audience quite naturally." Stageability, therefore, is not in itself a limitation of the play.

8. The Historical Significance of the Play

"Gahan Ugras" is an important work of Maithili dramatic literature in Nepal's Mithila. It may be seen as a distinctive representative of the theatrical

tradition that followed the establishment of the Mithila Natya Kala Parishad in Janakpur in 1979.

9. Conclusion: An Integrated Dramaturgical Assessment

"Gahan Ugras" is an ambitious attempt, guided by political and social purpose, to join folk-theatre traditions with modern political drama. It achieves considerable success through the effective movement of karuna rasa, the vigorous use of folk-performance traditions and its conception of a collective protagonist. Its partial employment of Brechtian distanciation and its political candour testify to its modernity.

Nevertheless, the play is not free from structural looseness, insufficient psychological development of characters, the absence of a clear nirvahana or resolution and practical difficulties of staging. Even so, the historical significance and cultural contribution of Parmeshwar Kapari's work within Maithili drama remain beyond dispute.

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STUDY II / NIT NAVAL

Virendra Mallick

Introduction

One of the defining characteristics of Virendra Mallick's writing is the way in which he connects the creative language of Maithili with the uncertainties of everyday life, social questions, and critical discernment. In his poetry, Mithila is not a fixed geography of memory but a living environment of hunger, labour, linguistic rights, urban displacement, and civic dissent. In his critical prose, questions of tradition, modernity, aesthetics, and literature's social responsibility emerge repeatedly.

The first two chapters of this book examine the poems of Agni-Shikha and Athato Kavya Jijnasa independently. The former collection speaks in an urgent voice of popular struggle and linguistic identity; the latter develops a range of questions concerning the environment, the ironies of development, the market, democracy, and the commodification of poetry. A fundamental aim of this study is to understand the relationship between these collections without erasing the diversity of their individual poems.

The third chapter uses Pratham Purush to examine the practice of criticism itself. In his discussions of Rama poetry, imagery, tradition and innovation, and contemporary poetry, Mallick accords importance to evidentiary reasoning, linguistic sensibility, and an understanding of form. The fourth chapter, on Drama and Theatre: Nature and Models, explores the relationship between text and performance, folk art and theatrical institutions, theatrical language and social memory. The fifth chapter brings together, thematically, the nine chapters of Mallick's extended critical study of love and beauty in Vidyapati.

Reading these five books together reveals a larger principle: in Mallick's literary thinking, creative freedom and historical responsibility are not antagonistic. When the vitality of poetry becomes connected with people's lives, close attention to its form, speaker, symbols, satire, and poetic language becomes equally necessary. Likewise, criticism acquires credibility where praise and interrogation, tradition and innovation, cultural intimacy and reasoned disagreement can coexist.

CHAPTER I • THE LITERATURE OF VIRENDRA MALLICK

Agni-Shikha

A sequential examination of 55 poems • People's lives, linguistic identity, poetic craft, and political satire

The sequence of poems in Agni-Shikha contains fifty entries, but five composite entries each comprise two distinct poems. It is therefore necessary to consider fifty-five separate compositions.

The method rests on four levels: (a) close reading of the primary text, attending to theme, figures, imagery, repetition, and the poetic speaker; (b) an internal study of political, economic, and cultural contexts; (c) analysis of vernacular usage, myth, Hindi–English lexical mixtures, and modes of utterance; and (d) ethical and critical examination, in which the poet's solidarity with ordinary people is assessed alongside exaggeration, violent rhetoric, and representations of women.

It would be mistaken always to regard references to 'I', 'you', 'he/she', or historical personalities in the poems as the poet's autobiography or verified historical fact. A poem is a creative linguistic document. To understand the significance of its politics, satire, and experience, this study distinguishes between the claims made within the text and independent historical verification.

2. Principal Ideological Debates across the Collection

2.1 The Polysemous Symbol of Fire

The title Agni-Shikha gives the entire collection symbolic unity. In 'From the City to the Village', fire signifies the desire for fierce rebellion; in 'Evening', the colour of that fire writes a love letter upon the lake; in 'Naxalite', the sun's red light becomes a warning of struggle; in the title poem, fire becomes the energy of social surgery and illumination. Fire is thus not merely a destructive power but also a possibility of memory, renewal, scrutiny, and creation.

A related cluster of symbols includes heated iron, red rays, burning cooking fires, bombs, gunpowder, missiles, and electricity. The poet reshapes an ancient conception of fire through the vocabulary of modern technology. As a result, scenes of popular revolution and the fire that cooks daily bread continually transform into one another.

2.2 Linguistic Identity: Rights and Self-Criticism

The question of Maithili's rights recurs in 'A Box of Revolution', 'My Dear Indira', 'The Maithili Movement', 'To an Impotent Leader', and 'A Copy of a Letter'. Education in the mother tongue, constitutional recognition, literary publication, and respect for one's own linguistic identity are interconnected

problems. The poet does not settle for emotional slogans in defence of the language; he also attacks the movement's failures, the complacency of its leadership, and the inertia of his own community.

In 'My Dear Indira' and 'A Box of Revolution', the demand for Maithili's inclusion in the Eighth Schedule belongs to the political circumstances in which the poems were written. According to the external constitutional record, Maithili was included through the Ninety-Second Constitutional Amendment of 2003, published in the Gazette on 8 January 2004. This evidence establishes the historical context of the earlier demand, but it does not establish that every poem in the collection was composed in the same year.

2.3 Hunger, Labour, and Economic Inequality

Agricultural debt, school fees, and the absence of books in the mother tongue in 'Electric Pressure'; workers and students in 'In the Courtyard of Independence'; the oppressed people of 'Struggle for Liberation'; the proletariat in 'To Those of a Common Conviction'; and workers and the market in 'The Liberated Market' together make the reality of labour a persistent thread throughout the collection. In this people's poetry, class relationships are not merely abstract slogans: they take shape through queues for rations, paper and pencils, pawned jewellery, kerosene, and failed harvests.

Cultural exploitation accompanies economic exploitation. Those who speak the people's language are denied education, respect, and opportunities to publish; those whose labour sustains the countryside remain separated from the returns on what they produce. The collection treats both forms of inequality as manifestations of the same injustice.

2.4 The Distortion of Democracy and Political Satire

Chairs of office, leaders, ministers, village heads, panchayats, police officers, bureaucrats, courts, and members of parliament recur with exceptional frequency in the collection. Files and red tape in 'Zero Hour', Yama's realm in 'Yama's Journey Abroad', changing colours in 'Chameleon', carrion-eating greed in 'Vulture', and the diseased social body in 'Cancer' are distinct metaphors of power. The central anxiety is that administration and politics should become machinery for self-preservation rather than instruments of service to citizens.

A significant contradiction inhabits this political outlook: demands for democratic rights are frequently expressed in the military vocabulary of conflict. Any assessment of these works must examine the poet's opposition to exploitation separately from the intensity of his poetic rhetoric.

2.5 Mithila, the City, and Social Geography

The poet does not regard Mithila as a sealed cultural monument. References to Ranti, Mangrauni, Pilakhwar, Madhubani, Darbhanga, Janakpur, Patna, Calcutta, and other places in 'His Village: His City' create an extensive spatial network. In 'In the Name of Our Folk Knowledge', the fragrance of soil and water is bound to feudal structures, poverty, popular livelihoods, and the

sufferings of ordinary people. In the poet's vision, Mithila is not a static object of pride but a social terrain continually subjected to questioning.

Urban signs—trams, bus stops, hotels, prisons, offices, cinemas, and shopping malls—collide with rural vocabulary: ponds, rohu and bhakur fish, finger millet, orchards, fields, and bamboo groves. This encounter ensures that the experience of Maithil modernity is not reducible to an imported form.

2.6 Myth, Religion, and Cultural Self-Examination

Numerous figures from the Ramayana and Mahabharata become political metaphors in these poems. The repeated humiliation of Sita and Saraswati, Ravana's politics of disguise, Surasa's unemployment, Kumbhakarna's sleep, Dronacharya's institutional injustice, Ekalavya's struggle, the impediment of the chakravyuha, and Yama's absence turn mythic narratives into a language for contemporary inequality.

The poet's attack on religion is generally fiercest where ritual has come to substitute for social responsibility. In 'Kirtan', 'The Prayer Room', and 'Chodanalakshano 'rtho Dharmah', the ironic deployment of religious terminology is directed not against faith as such but against public conduct obscured by hypocrisy and self-interest.

2.7 Images of Women and the Absence of Women's Voices

Women appear in many roles: tradition in the metropolis in 'The Maithil Woman'; waiting in 'Evening'; the measured body in 'Mini Girl'; concern for mother, sister, wife, and beloved in 'Agni-Shikha'; women's awakening in 'Guerrilla Warfare'; and a woman subjected to violence in 'Gujaratnama'. The range of these appearances merits literary attention.

Yet a critical question remains: how often do women speak in their own voices, and how often do they become merely symbols in the poet's political argument? The bodily imagery of 'Mini Girl' and 'The Prayer Room' invites readers to undertake this examination themselves. The collection's solidarity with ordinary people must also be read in relation to women's autonomous experience.

2.8 The Writer, Literary Institutions, and the Aesthetics of Resistance

One distinctive achievement of the collection is that, in writing about politics, the poet also examines poets, intellectuals, critics, prize committees, and publishing institutions. Cultural events in 'Among Four Hundred Thousand Monkeys', the older leadership in 'O My Elders', book publication in 'A Copy of a Letter', and the role of poetry in 'Kavitayah Prativadam' and 'Kavitashri Pataliputram' all become subjects of direct debate.

In this sense, the poems are not only opposed to external political arrangements; they are also exercises in self-criticism within the literary field. The poet's insistence is clear: literature must remain connected to the pain and struggles of everyday life. At the same time, the readings demonstrate the need

to preserve literature's internal beauty, contradictions, and multiplicity of meanings beyond its political usefulness.

2.9 The Reach of Historical Time: From Early Popular Movements to Globalisation

Political rhetoric associated with Indira, Bangladesh, demands for entry into the Eighth Schedule, Naxalites, the fodder and hawala scandals, globalisation, the violence in Gujarat, and 'Big Bazaar' all provide signs of different periods. The thematic range of the collection therefore extends across multiple historical layers. Without authoritative publication information, one should not assign a definite publication date to the book or an unverified date of composition to each poem.

The poems of the market-oriented era do not treat older injustices as having disappeared; they recognise their reappearance in changing forms. The final question in 'The Liberated Market' connects with the initial energy of revolt in the collection and opens a new possibility of struggle grounded in reason.

3. Language, Poetic Craft, and Aesthetic Sensibility

3.1 Vernacular Vocabulary and Multilingual Texture

The collection places everyday Maithili verb forms, indigenous terms for objects, invective, altered forms of speech, myths, and the vocabulary of agricultural labour alongside modern expressions such as tram, refrigerator, Prestige pressure cooker, letterbox, blood bank, ultraviolet rays, missile, hybrid, and mall. This mixture brings different levels of social existence onto a single linguistic plane. The limited presence of Hindi, English, and Sanskrit formulae can be understood as a poetic strategy within the Maithili voice; the present study itself is written in Maithili prose.

3.2 Free Verse, Collage, and Dramatic Utterance

Most poems are in free verse. Some offer a barrage of questions, others extended passages, others only two or three lines, and still others place a single word on each line. The visual arrangement of 'Vishnuryonim', the deployment of full stops in 'Kavitashri Pataliputram', the rhythmic miniature 'Evening', and the theatricality of 'Among Four Hundred Thousand Monkeys' exemplify this variety. The absence of metrical song does not mean the absence of rhythm: forms of address and repetition generate a distinct oral rhythm of resistance.

3.3 Principal Families of Images

Fire and light, disease and the body, animals and crowds, houses and walls, fields and hunger, war and weapons, cities and stages, and religion and ritual: these eight families of images recur throughout almost the entire collection. The searing presence of death in 'Vulture' and 'Cancer', the decay of structures in 'Let a New House Rise' and 'The Banyan Afflicted by Woodworm', and the

transformation of light in 'Evening' and 'Agni-Shikha' clarify the collection's internal organisation when read in relation to one another.

3.4 The Sharpness of Satire and the Risks of Meaning

Images of donkeys, dogs, monkeys, jackals, snakes, chameleons, and vultures are exceptionally harsh in their portrayal of ruling groups. Such satire can immediately engage the popular reader, but it also risks compressing the complexities of human behaviour into a single animal type. An adequate understanding of both the originality and the limitations of these works emerges from that tension.

4. Detailed Poem-by-Poem Criticism: All 55 Distinct Texts

The following sequence follows the actual printed page order of the original book. Each commentary first addresses subject and context, then examines craft, symbols, or critical implications. Page references in parentheses refer to the printed pages of the original book.

1. From the City to the Village (pp. 9–11)

At the beginning of the collection, the poet imagines himself as a 'madman', a fire spreading from the city into the village. This madness names resistance to passivity. Urban plunderers, village moneylenders who charge usurious interest, corrupt politicians, dishonest village heads, and failed educational institutions converge into a single social crisis. References to Sita, Saraswati, Ravana, and the Kosi, Kamala, and Balan rivers transform Mithila's cultural geography into a political language. The poet's anger is directed not at any one individual but at the entire network of exploitation.

The repeated declaration of spreading like fire at both the beginning and the end gives the poem a circular form. River water signifies both a final hope and resistance beyond control. The desire for a 'people's revolution' is explicit, but the hyperbole associated with fire and the imagery of warfare should be understood as a poetic summons, not as a literal prediction of historical events.

2. A Morsel of Flesh (pp. 12–13)

Government promises, official positions, and seats of power are depicted as the temptation of 'a morsel of flesh'. Individuals and organisations fall upon this small advantage, forgetting collective rights as they fight members of their own class. Images of venomous snakes, dogs, and bones expose the unequal relationship between powerless communities and the authorities. The poet's sharp accusations extend equally to leaders, students, intellectuals, and political activists.

References to the Gita, Kamasutra, and Vidyapati Padavali do not constitute an attack on these texts; they satirise self-satisfied reading divorced from context. The refusal to acknowledge one's mother tongue and mother becomes an extreme image of cultural self-forgetting. Interrogative and insulting statements impel readers towards self-criticism.

3. A Box of Revolution (pp. 14–15)

Exposing the coercive realities of government, the poet questions writers, students, and the general public. Central subjects include the demand for Maithili's inclusion in the Eighth Schedule, the right to education in one's mother tongue, and the tendency to elect unworthy representatives by voting on caste lines. The poem explores the political influence of words, the pen, and popular strength. The 'box' of the title also suggests a packaged, hollow, and performative revolution.

The recurring formula concerning 'the strength of the one who holds the stick' is a satirical alteration of a popular proverb. Beneath the fierce challenge, the poet raises questions about a movement's actual preparedness and self-discipline. The concrete demand for linguistic rights, voiced in anger, distinguishes the poem.

4. O My Elders, Be Still (pp. 16–17)

This poem is a direct statement of generational conflict. Addressing the older generation as his 'elders', the poet describes them as comfort-seeking, hungry for office, self-satisfied, and indifferent to their mother tongue. Details of oil lamps, kerosene, matchsticks, clerks, peons, meetings, cards, and board games evoke trivial routines and an unfulfilled public responsibility. The central demand is that the old leadership should not stand in the way of the new generation.

Its imperative title is superficially deferential but inwardly acerbic. 'Be still' expresses no wish for death; it is a political plea that the elders withdraw from public leadership and allow younger people to work. Small analogies drawn from everyday life and the urgency of the questions keep the poem alive despite its oratorical manner.

5. Bengal Bandh (pp. 18–19)

During the 'bandh', Calcutta's urban life lies under the shadow of fear, gunfire, bombs, arrests, and administrative repression. References to Alipore Jail, young blood shed in the name of Naxalism, and the Preventive Detention Act signal a particular political atmosphere within the text. Against this terror, the domestic conversation between Kalua Chamar and Chatura Chamain brings forward the ordinary person's practical concern with survival. A distance consequently opens between the public 'bandh' and private hunger and fear.

The city, like a cold corpse, and the Hindi-inflected dialogue of ordinary speech create opposing rhythms. Rather than merely offering slogans, the poet condenses popular humour, helplessness, and contradiction into a poem constructed as a scene.

6. Evening (p. 20)

This short lyric offers a moment of beauty amid the collection's sharp political voices. The sun's redness upon the lake seems like a name written in fire, while evening resembles a letter of reunion placed in a letterbox. In this

scene, nature and the objects of urban communication merge effortlessly. The poet turns the fading of light into anticipation of reunion rather than separation.

Within only a few lines, the poem employs symbols, visuality, and personification with restraint. Here 'fire' is not destructive but signifies the tender light of love. Understanding the enlargement of meaning carried by this one word is essential to reading the collection as a whole.

7. The Maithil Woman (p. 20)

The Maithil woman seen on Chowringhee, with kohl, vermilion, lips red as hibiscus, a red-patterned sari, and bare feet without sandals, constitutes the poem's visual scene. The encounter between the modern street of the metropolis and Mithila's traditional dress produces a tension of identity. To classify the woman simply as either 'backward' or 'modern' would narrow the reading.

This verbal portrait is extremely brief; beyond the descriptive perspective, the woman's own voice is absent. That limitation deserves consideration in a gender-focused reading. The combination of colour and dress constitutes the poem's concentrated visual strength.

8. Snake (p. 21)

The poet represents a deserted, silent day as a dead snake lying in the road. People are shut within the prisons of their homes: there is neither commotion nor struggle. Beneath external tranquillity, the poem conveys fear and the absence of living social consciousness. The snake is ordinarily a sign of danger or poison, but here its lifeless form signifies public inertia.

The reversal of a familiar comparison sharpens the poem. Three images—the motionless day, houses that have become prisons, and the unresponsive road—combine into a scene of political cowardice. Unlike the collection's numerous vehement poems, this poem's silence becomes a statement of resistance in its own right.

9. Master Sahib (p. 21)

This brief satire is built upon a teacher's changing language, clothing, and habit of visiting one household after another. Betel in his mouth, a watch on his wrist, English at one moment and Hindi at the next, sometimes a traditional dhoti and sometimes trousers: these details portray professional instability and the performance of outward appearances. The poem targets not the teacher's knowledge but the acting out of his social image.

The final comparison to a dog intensifies the sting of humiliation, but it would be inappropriate to apply such a generalisation to all teachers. The poem is more meaningful when read as a satire of a particular social type.

10. The Maithili Movement (p. 22)

The movement for linguistic rights is compared to a child's firecracker that fails to explode. Endless waiting and inaction, in place of popular awakening,

are the poem's central objects of satire. Symbolic events are staged in the name of struggle, yet they produce no results; the poet questions this discrepancy.

The image of an ordinary household firecracker immediately exposes the emptiness of political claims. The extreme brevity of the poem makes its satire keener. Read alongside the collection's other movement-oriented poems, it is also an act of self-criticism within the poet's own political camp.

11. Mini Girl (p. 22)

Through transparent clothing, bodily proportions, and numerical measurements, 'Mini Girl' sketches a sharp picture of urban fashion. The consumerist gaze that turns a woman's body into measurements is unmistakable. Whether the poem's own utterance critiques that objectification or reproduces it, however, remains an open question.

List-like short phrases, numerical markers, and bodily detail make up its experimental arrangement. The absence of the woman's personhood must be recognised as a significant critical limitation.

12. My Dear Indira (pp. 23–24)

With its English form of address, the title speaks to the Indian authorities as though in a direct letter. The demand for Maithili's inclusion in the Eighth Schedule, the rejection of promises, and the self-respect of Maithili speakers occupy the centre of the poem. The roaring Kamala–Balan and Kosi rivers, names marking the geographical spread of Mithila, and the memory of Lava and Kusha create the image of a cultural community in agitation.

The succession of 'fire', 'fire engine', 'heated iron', and 'challenge' heightens emotional intensity. The contrast between the title's familiarity and the poem's severe political voice is important. The poem should be read as a poetic document of a contemporary demand, but its date of composition must not be fixed without evidence.

13. In the Courtyard of Independence (pp. 25–26)

Students, labourers, and farmers standing in the courtyard of an independent nation remain deprived of substantive freedom. Students confront unemployment, examination irregularities, and tear gas; farmers contend with droughts and floods, the ironies of subsidies, ration queues, and hunger. By setting lived reality against such public slogans as 'Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan', the poet exposes the difference between formal independence and social self-rule.

Repetition of the same phrase links different social figures. The conjunction of Surasa from the Ramayana with the 'laboratory' of development planning brings myth and the vocabulary of the modern state into critical contact. The poem's voice expands beyond individual indignation towards a shared class experience.

14. Kirtan (pp. 27–28)

The poet turns the religious-cultural form of kirtan into a metaphor for the public display staged by governments, assemblies, offices, and politicians. Amid strikes, holidays, beer, the commercial embellishment of bodies, extended devotional rituals, and organised stage events, democracy's real responsibilities disappear from sight. Religious vocabulary is not deployed here as a universal assault on belief but as an instrument of satire directed against the numbing of politics and society through hypocritical spectacles.

Noise, shifting scenes, and catalogues of comparisons transform the poem into a crowded theatre. The collision between obscenity and ritual calls the pretensions of civilisation into question. An exceptionally dense accumulation of images sometimes complicates the meaning; nevertheless, this complexity is linked to the poet's fragmented sense of his historical moment.

15. Cancer (pp. 29–30)

'Cancer' transforms disease into a metaphor for spreading inertia, selfishness, and institutional disintegration within the social body. Teachers, physicians, politicians, ministers, and intellectuals have abandoned their respective duties. Courts, official chairs, elections, rations, foreign borrowing, and inflation appear as many ailments of public life. The true subject is not an individual's illness but the disorders of a society that has forsaken its obligations.

An almost uninterrupted sequence of questions, along with medical terminology, generates an awareness of crisis on several levels. The poem insists on the need to diagnose social disease but supplies no clear institutional programme of treatment—a natural limitation of its declaratory style.

16. The Prayer Room (pp. 31–32)

Broken idols, incense sticks, tear gas, red tape, and election materials occupy the same visual field in the prayer room. By bringing together objects associated with a place of worship and a government office, the poet reveals the extent to which humanity, consciousness, and justice have been fragmented. In formal terms, severed limbs, pronouns, and bodily symbols create a visual text of social disintegration.

The unusual combination of objects produces an effect akin to surrealist collage. Images of the female body require critical scrutiny: they may expose objectification by structures of power, or the poetic language itself may repeat that objectification. Both possibilities demand examination.

17. Among Four Hundred Thousand Monkeys (pp. 33–34)

The poet portrays collections, welcomes, speeches, stage arrangements, anticipation of performers, and the audience's appetites inside a cultural auditorium as the behaviour of a troop of monkeys. The auditorium becomes a mocking counterpart of a literary-cultural institution. The programme's original purpose is forgotten, while the organisers' display, commotion, and prurient discussion of women's bodies become dominant.

The collision of 'monkey', 'Hanuman', 'time bomb', and 'pressure cooker' satirically joins folk comparison with modern devices. The number is an instrument of hyperbole, not a factual count of spectators. The poem's barbs are aimed at the internal contradictions of literary gatherings.

18. In the Name of Our Folk Knowledge (pp. 35–39)

This long poem is one of the collection's centres of self-criticism. Calling himself a 'sinner', the poet accepts a responsibility to expose the suffering of his land and water, local traditions of knowledge, labourers, poor farmers, urban workers, and the disadvantaged. He opposes the tendency to conceal present-day illiteracy, disregard for the mother tongue, and social inequality behind prestigious images of Vidyapati, Sita, Ayachi, and Mandana. A continuing tension persists between inherited cultural memory and present deprivation.

Repeated self-accusation works as both self-satire and ethical resistance. In the collection, 'lokaveda' becomes not merely folk culture but a capacious name for the social knowledge, labour, and rights of living communities. Here the poet's commitment to ordinary people is most direct.

19. Naxalite (pp. 40–41)

Beginning with the red morning sun, missiles, bombs, and images of struggle, the poem turns towards a state of mind inclined to escape. Scenes of residence in Kashi, river ghats, worship, and urban exploitation describe more than a sacred city; they exemplify people fleeing from consciousness and responsibility. The title 'Naxalite' raises difficult questions about armed upheaval and society's reaction to it.

Fragments of dreams, violent symbols, urban prostitution, and self-forgetting unsettle the reading experience. The poet reveals concealed connections among reports of violence, class inequality, and political passivity. The work should not be reduced to a simple political declaration.

20. Electric Pressure (pp. 42–44)

An ocean of hunger, agricultural distress, debt, school fees, the lack of mother-tongue books, and unemployment form the poem's basis. Memories of traditionally abundant food are placed against the severe life of an impoverished household today. Modern terms—tractor, pumping set, vitamins, blood bank—are linked to the realities of agrarian society. Ritual worship alone cannot end hunger, disease, and economic crisis: the poet argues for active transformation.

The 'pressure' of the title suggests constraint, an imbalance of energy, and a sudden shock. The repeated question 'How much longer?' becomes a demand that the system change within historical time. Labour, health, education, and language are interconnected popular rights in this poem.

21. Guerrilla Warfare (pp. 45–47)

This poem is an extended summons to the makers of a new age. Images of floods, drought, destitution, a daughter grown pale, an unemployed son, and

elderly parents establish the grounds for resistance to the existing order. The desire for renewal is accompanied by references to women's public agency and 'women's awakening'. The poet regards the long habit of enduring injustice as an obstacle to change and gives political struggle a ferociously militant vocabulary.

The constant recurrence of 'Come!' creates the rhythm of a lyrical invocation. Weapons, strategy, and guerrilla warfare are elements of the poem's political rhetoric; criticism must also consider their human costs, nonviolent democratic possibilities, and rhetorical excess. This anger should be read as a historical social document.

22. Zero Hour (pp. 48–49)

'Zero Hour' is a poem about a present incapable of decision. The poet is disturbed by the passivity or opportunism of poets, historians, intellectuals, leaders, and ministers alike. Office files, bureaucratic red tape, bribes, land consolidation, ministers' palaces of glass, and the plates pawned by ordinary people are different manifestations of the same system. The everyday humiliation of the public within the processes of democracy renders this historical moment 'zero'.

Through numerous interrogative addresses, the poet exposes a failure of leadership. The poem becomes an inventory of problems, but the very inventory lays bare a machinery of exploitation extending from local administration to national government. 'Zero' time is not an inert void; it is a period of waiting for decisive action.

23. Let a New House Rise: Let the Old House Fall (pp. 50–56)

This is among the collection's longest and most declarative works. The 'house' is not merely a building: it stands for the social order, caste-based customs, inherited authority, and mental rigidity. Both the demolition of the old structure and construction upon new foundations are demanded together. While acknowledging Mithila's dignity and glory, the poet seeks remedies for its poverty, illiteracy, flattery, and institutional weakness. Rather than merely invoking illustrious ancestors, he emphasises concrete responsibilities in the present.

Single-word lines, abrupt pauses, questions, commands, and sequential declarations give the poem the form of an activist manifesto. The idea of the 'new house' is constructive, although the militaristic language of some lines raises critical questions about its democratic implications. The poem's essential strength is its valuation of social reconstruction above inherited prestige.

24. The Drama of Being Thrust into Yet Another Hell (pp. 57–58)

Descending one flight of steps after another without reaching the end of hell: this opening image shows the cycle of unsuccessful change. One individual or party replaces another, yet the system once again grinds down ordinary people. Amid the celebrations of victory, the poet asks about grief,

poison, and darkness. The duty to liberate one's mother tongue and mother is placed above personal convenience.

Towards the end, the insistence 'We need jobs, not knowledge' and 'We need work, not sermons' turns from abstract ideas towards concrete livelihoods. The poem thereby exposes the distance between slogans and social practice. The repetition of 'hell' signifies not an inescapable destiny but systemic oppression capable of being changed.

25. Playing with a Gun against a Yelping Dog (pp. 59–61)

The poet urges young writers not to be intimidated by the status quo. Deceitful administrators, opportunist leaders, politics, and the empty promise of 'eradicating poverty' are subjected to ridicule. The poem regards words, language, and writing as instruments of struggle; in the poet's view, opposing powers are accomplished at changing disguises, so agents of change must remain vigilant.

Addresses such as 'Beware!', 'Watch out!', and 'Be alert!' generate a rhythm of political warning. Images of Gulliver and the scale of mountains reverse familiar proportions. When the linguistic 'weapon' of this text is understood as a metaphor for resistant writing, the obligations of literature become particularly prominent.

26. Vishnuryonim (p. 62)

Departing from conventional syntax, this short experimental poem presents a sequence of isolated words relating to the body, clothing, breath, touch, and sensation. Instead of a unified story or injunction, it offers a fragmented verbal picture of sensory experience. The distance between its Sanskritised title and the vernacular vocabulary of the body invites reflection on the relationship between ritual purity and material sensation.

The placing of individual words on separate lines, empty spaces, and incompleteness of meaning are essential to its craft. To confine sexual experience within a definitive moral verdict would impoverish the possibilities of reading. The visual arrangement of the printed page is especially important here.

27. War (p. 63)

In only a few lines, the poet approaches profound divisions and questions of rights through the image of 'war'. The great distance and gulf between 'us' and 'them' appear difficult to bridge through ordinary accommodation. Because the poem is so short, every word bears the weight of a political decision.

The metaphors of rights, struggle, and distance are exceptionally compressed. 'War' may suggest either a symbolic social confrontation or literal conflict; the task of criticism is not to assume an endorsement of violence but to analyse the pressure exerted by actual inequalities.

28. Unconquerable (p. 63)

Addressing God, the speaker declares his determination not to bow. The confrontation among faith, doubt, and self-respect forms the heart of this miniature poem. Instead of relying on divine power, the speaker trusts his own judgment and resolve.

The resolute bearing of the body—standing with chest expanded—transforms political struggle into an individual ethical commitment. The collection's broad vocabulary of revolt is compressed here into very few words.

29. Dynamism (p. 64)

This short poem accepts identity as an ongoing process of change. The sense of 'I am no longer what I was' signals transformations in life, experience, and thought. The speaker leaves the final judgment of his new self to others.

The unresolved ending of this self-portrait makes the reader an active participant. Amid the collection's collective and declaratory songs, this is a subtle pause for introspection.

30. The State of Affairs (p. 64)

Mithila's social and political landscape is portrayed through images of lions, tigers, dogs, and monkeys. Genuine strength is rare and deceptive imitation is everywhere; nevertheless, the poet retains hope that the masks will fall in due course and real power will awaken again.

Animal metaphors make vernacular satire immediately accessible. The title 'The State of Affairs' promises an account of reality, but the ending establishes a hopeful vision of the future. Its political intent resides in a symbolic structure built around the qualities and failings assigned to the animals.

31. To an Impotent Leader (pp. 65–66)

The title is a sharp satire on the capitulation of leadership. The poet argues that a leader who sacrificed his life in the struggle for his mother tongue would deserve greater respect than one who sold his community's identity for private advantage. Registering another language in the census, extracting personal gain at the expense of the poor, and degrading cultural value are the principal accusations.

The recurring 'I wish' becomes an extreme exaggeration of public ethical responsibility, rather than a literal wish for anyone's death. It is necessary to consider the satirical meaning of such aggressive utterances separately from their literal wording. The poem raises questions of accountability between leaders and the public.

32. Today (pp. 67–68)

The past locked in a box, the present scattered across the road, and the future wandering like a red ray through mist: these three images of time give the poem its direction. Hunger in city and village, light imprisoned in safes, government slogans, and bureaucratic sycophancy become the contradictions

of contemporary life. People 'eat' speeches instead of food; inflation and corruption diminish the conditions of civic existence.

Personification and satirical transformation are especially effective here. 'Today' is not simply a date on the calendar but an entire time suspended between a vanished dream of independence and an unfulfilled future.

33. Crime (pp. 69–70)

Demolishing the old house and establishing new social values are called 'crimes': the poet challenges this inverted conception of justice. Traditional codes of conduct, linguistic establishments, and self-serving critics suppress new ideas. The poet experiences repeated punishment for refusing to bow, yet the image of fresh seeds germinating from blood creates a possibility of change that cannot be extinguished.

The title 'Crime' is a satirical inversion: the perpetrator of genuine injustice is respected, while the critic of injustice stands accused. Images of coating words with tar and imposing a death sentence figure the suppression of artistic expression.

34. Vulture (pp. 71–72)

The vulture represents the parasitic character of power. Exploiters feasting on bodies emptied of blood and marrow, rising prices, crises at the country's borders, and domestic terror inhabit the same image. The poet imagines words becoming gunpowder when the system tightens its grip around the people's throats.

Images of wings, mouths, blood, and bones render social humiliation bodily and palpable. The reference to Bangladesh bears witness to a wider political memory of the subcontinent, but one should not attach every metaphor in the poem to a single historical event in a linear manner.

35. Struggle for Liberation (pp. 73–74)

A people crushed beneath a crumbling wall erected by their ancestors constitutes the poem's central image. Beginning with an address to shared suffering, the poet attacks political intermediaries, compromising elites, hunger, and the injustice of food being snatched from people's mouths. The appearance of 'my poetry' and 'my words' shows literature accepting a duty not merely to record society's pain but actively to oppose it.

Images of walls, nails, bones, steel ploughshares, and fire intensify the physical experience of suffering. The final criticism of poverty becoming 'fashionable' identifies literary and political hypocrisy together.

36. Agni-Shikha (pp. 75–76)

The title poem brings together the poetic vision of the entire collection. Amid countless small lights, a single tongue of flame is imagined as capable of piercing intellectual conceit, envy, selfishness, and misgovernment. Images drawn from modern science—'ultraviolet rays', surgery, and the 'operating table'—give a new scientific form to fire's established religious symbolism.

The waiting of father, mother, sister, beloved, and wife reveals the domestic and human stakes of struggle.

The interplay between public action and private grief gives the poem its deep emotional force. Fire is not destruction alone: it also signifies diagnosis of a diseased society, warmth in relationships near death, and a ray of hope. The family's voices humanise the abstract figure of the militant protagonist.

37. His Village: His City (pp. 77–79)

This poem constructs the life story of a disadvantaged individual wandering from village to city. A sequence of villages, towns, and metropolises across Mithila is accompanied by an inventory of fields, orchards, ponds, libraries, lawsuits, untouchability, poverty, unemployment, urban exploitation, and the hunger for office. This geographical list is not simply a record of places; it maps dispersed experiences of labour and humiliation.

Short sentences and repeated full stops convey the broken mobility of an exhausted life. Rather than presenting the village as an immutable paradise or the city as an unqualified hell, the poem reveals the distinct injustices and possibilities of both. Concrete place-names lend authenticity to the poem's social realism.

38. To Those of a Common Conviction (pp. 80–82)

This is a work of political self-examination addressed to people who share a similar ideological ground. The shell of 'Tiger Brand', a speechmaking jackal, people caught in cycles of promises, and the merchant's safe expose the disguises of power. Actual economic inequality is set against claims about democracy, socialism, justice, and the elimination of poverty. The reduction of an individual to a 'vote' is a central sign of a crisis in civic dignity.

Direct address, striking comparisons, and economic vocabulary form the poem's chief devices. It does not categorically reject imported ideas; rather, it questions the emptiness of theories disconnected from local realities.

39. Yama's Journey Abroad (pp. 83–85)

In Yama's absence the state itself has become 'Yamapuri', the realm of death: this satirical narrative premise directs the poem. Crowds in the capital, government officials, the businessman's safe, famine, darkness, terror, student anger, and the failure of justice construct a scene of social death. The mythical Yama marks the cruelty of modern government: the god of death is abroad, but the machinery of death is at work at home.

The transformation of myth, extensive arrangements of objects, and absurd governmental ceremonies are the principal sources of its satire. Modern equipment, economic resources, and ancient narrative appear together to construct a strange political reality.

40. Chameleon (pp. 86–89)

The poet compares the opportunist politician's changes of appearance, flag, party, clothing, and speech to the shifting colours of a chameleon. A sharp

contrast emerges between outward politeness and inner exploitation. Masks of praise, prizes, office, public service, and ideology conceal the individual's self-interest. The satire also attacks opportunism in literary establishments, not merely among politicians.

The long succession of changing colours is, in effect, a many-faced drama of moral bankruptcy. The mixture of cosmetics, imported goods, and religious and political symbols reveals the poet's playful yet bitter language. The poem's real centre is not changing one's appearance but changing one's values to protect self-interest.

41. The Banyan Afflicted by Woodworm (pp. 90–94)

The banyan is traditionally a symbol of an old, immense order, cultural protection, and collective shelter. The poet shows that woodworms have invaded its interior: comfort-seeking, bribes, counterfeit patriotism, the defence of caste and lineage, recommendations for awards, and the disregard of popular voices. The poem develops through several marked sections, each revealing a different form of public hypocrisy. Feudal memory and modern institutional corruption appear to support one another.

The image of the diseased tree binds the long poem together. The decorated swan, tiger skin, parade of skeletons, and images of parliament expose fear and the artificiality of prestige. 'Woodworm' suggests a decay that advances from within and is easily concealed by external magnificence.

42. Calcutta and Rajkamal (pp. 95–100)

Centred on Rajkamal Chaudhary, this poem goes beyond a commemorative recollection to recreate the personality of a creative rebel. The poet presents Rajkamal as an advocate of innovation, an opponent of the establishment, and a supporter of the world's younger generation. Calcutta's trams, Kalighat, Behala, prostitution, capital, and exploitation enter as scenes of his conflict-ridden urban world. His bilingual creative work in Maithili and Hindi and references to Kankavati generate literary intertextuality.

The Rajkamal of the poem is not an incontestable body of biographical facts but a creative personality constructed through the poet's judgments. Maintaining this distinction is essential to scholarship. The concentrated language of the city, the body, and fire itself enters into dialogue with Rajkamal's modernist poetic world.

43. There Was So Much I Wanted to Tell You (pp. 101–102)

A cold December evening, a bus stop, a crowd of travellers, and the wait for the 'Two Down' awaken the memory of an old acquaintance, Manjari Dasgupta. Former love, the years of youth, office files, domestic obligations, and inflation come together in the present. The past of love is not merely a sweet recollection: intervening life has been surrounded by economic and familial constraints.

Precise details of urban space and direct address to one person add private delicacy to the collection's generally collective voice. The movement of time,

changing appearance, and memory-charged scenes give the poem an autobiographical tone, but the poetic 'I' need not be taken as evidence about the poet's own life.

44. Kavitayah Prativadam (pp. 103–104)

The social responsibility of poetic creation is the central question here. In the midst of communal riots, casteism, political murder, hunger, exploitation, and economic inequality, the poet objects to complacency with writing only hymns of praise, elegies, or love letters. Poetry is established as an ethical force of opposition; writers are called upon to declare where they stand.

The Sanskritised title and direct forms of address such as 'my friend' and 'comrade' create tension at the linguistic level. The final questions—whether the definition of poetry should change and whether poetry should examine itself—turn the work into an ongoing critical dialogue rather than a closed doctrine.

45. Salutation to the Setting Sun (pp. 105–107)

Amid the image of the descending sun and encroaching darkness, the poet perceives a light that continues to struggle. Warriors shining like lamps in the ocean of time, night, gunfire, bombs, the cries of women, and the failure of policing form a shared sequence of scenes. The sun is setting, but the struggle has not ended; fire still burns in villages, towns, and cities.

The sudden transition from a scene of nature to political imagery is the poem's principal compositional method. The salutation signifies not surrender but respect for a sun that never ceases to struggle. Questioning the futility of waiting for heroes, the poet treats the present as an opportunity for people to awaken themselves.

46. Kavitashri Pataliputram (pp. 108–109)

The poem opens with the irony that opposing the government has come to be declared a crime in a democracy. The poet rigorously examines the relationship between poetry and rebellion: when words lose their connection to popular movements, the active participation of farmers and workers, and the struggles of actual life, they become ornaments of the establishment. The distinction between 'rebellion' and 'the semblance of rebellion' is the poem's theoretical centre.

An unusual proliferation of full stops deliberately blurs the boundaries between prose, manifesto, and poetry. Lists of blood, sickles, knives, slogans, and files construct a map of social classes and political power. The poet emphasises literature's political usefulness, alongside which criticism must also raise the question of artistic autonomy.

47. A Copy of a Letter (pp. 110–112)

Addressed to Mohan Bharadwaj, this epistolary poem criticises literary publishing and institutional arrangements. Nepotism, lineage loyalties, official positions, the dominance of established scholars, and systems of patronage obstruct the publication of new writers' books. Mythological

examples of Karna, Dadhichi, Ekalavya, Dronacharya, Abhimanyu, and the chakravyuha expose the institutional struggle of a younger generation.

The tension that develops between the affectionate opening, 'Dear Brother', and the final language of battle is particularly striking. Figures from the traditional Mahabharata become metaphors for relations of power within modern publishing. The poem gives concrete form to the collection's self-criticism of literary institutions.

48. People Have Begun to Hear Now (pp. 113–114)

The poem's main assertion is that people have begun to recognise the language of speeches, the ruler's smile, and hollow claims of socialism. Images of young blood, the furnace of hunger, chess moves, and the cremation ground reveal the oppressive character of the ruling class. At the end, the poet refuses to identify as his own a country controlled by criminals and exploiters.

The recurrence of 'now' marks a changing moment in public consciousness. The image of approaching footsteps arouses hope for the arrival of a new sun. Here the people are not merely victims but active historical agents who have begun to scrutinise power.

49. Beware (p. 115)

Written against a background of globalisation, destructive weaponry, terrorism, and the uncertainties of the twenty-first century, this poem calls for collective vigilance. At the level of its utterance, national security, trust in the people's strength, and protection against destructive tendencies in disguise are prominent. The poet's attention now moves beyond Mithila's immediate concerns towards crises in the world order.

Explosive clusters of words and urgent warnings determine the poem's movement. Its demand for decisions grounded in the people gives its concern with security a democratic possibility. The balance between language that generates fear and intelligent caution requires critical examination.

50. Be Alert (p. 116)

This poem is a declaration of the writer's resolve against the status quo, servility, and sycophancy. Silence in the face of political intimidation or government power does not fulfil literature's responsibilities. By calling writing a missile and language a brahmastra, the poet announces the awakening power of words.

Repetition of 'no' creates a rhythm of rejection. Ideologically, the poem enters into dialogue with 'Playing with a Gun against a Yelping Dog' on page 59, but it is not a verbatim reprint of that earlier composition: new political contexts and the metaphor of the 'human bomb' enter this later poem. It is important to preserve that difference in reading.

51. Stay Vigilant (p. 117)

Anarchy, scandals, terrorist violence, criminalisation, and wrongdoing protected by state power form the poem's catalogue of crises. The poet sees the

country's soil, water, and people's identity as being at stake. Security is needed not only at the border but also in the ethical conduct of politics and administration.

The title is itself a word of warning. The combined final utterance, 'Be alert, stay vigilant', turns the preceding two poems and this one into a brief trilogy of warnings. Resistant language, public vigilance, and civil rights are intertwined throughout the trilogy.

52. A View of the Nation: At the Threshold of the Twentieth Century (pp. 118–122)

This long poem attempts a comprehensive social and political portrait of the end of the century. The fodder scandal, hawala, St Kitts, commercialised media, consumerist economics, electronic advertising, caste- and religion-based politics, and environmental crisis are connected as aspects of a broad collapse of values. The presence of Western popular culture and Indian classical music 'on one stage' becomes an image of cultural mixture.

News-like details, exchanges of dialogue, and indignant comparisons give the poem the voice of a contemporary chronicle. Rather than treating cultural exchange in itself as decline, criticism needs to analyse separately the causes of the economic inequality, political opportunism, and media enchantment that the poem portrays. This constitutes the critical assessment of a multilayered text.

53. Gujaratnama (pp. 123–124)

'Gujaratnama' is an intense poem of resistance against communal violence. The poet expresses anguish over the cruelty of violent crowds, atrocities against women and children, administrative inaction, and the inhumanity of political triumphalism. The admission 'I feel deeply ashamed' becomes a sense of ethical guilt for failing to stand beside the victims in time.

The title becomes a poetic testimony to the memory of a public event; to cite the accusations within it as historical conclusions requires independent documentary verification. The poem should first be read as a direct statement of human compassion and opposition to communal violence.

54. Chodanalakshano 'rtho Dharmah (pp. 125–131)

A profound contradiction is established between the Sanskrit aphoristic title and the contemporary picture of electoral politics founded on religion, caste, and community. The poem presents an extended picture of kidnapping, ransom, criminalisation, failure of law enforcement, money power, caste fragmentation, and intellectual silence. The question of genuine ethical justice becomes central in the face of deception conducted in religion's name. That the dispossessed remain voiceless even under a supposedly 'democratic' order is the poet's fundamental concern.

Long declarations, report-like details, furious adjectives, and contradictory scenes are its compositional devices. The title's classical language becomes a measure for testing the ethical emptiness of modern political conduct. The

original philosophical context of the quoted Sanskrit aphorism must not be confused with its satirical meaning in this poem.

55. The Liberated Market (pp. 132–135)

The collection's final poem focuses on the social consequences of economic liberalisation and market ideology. Amid the appeal of television sets, refrigerators, malls, Big Bazaar, multinational companies, advertising, and foreign products, it depicts the crisis of indigenous industries, the suffering of workers, class inequality, and middle-class aspiration. Even when the market is 'liberated', the lives of the people are not: therein lies the title's central irony.

The poet connects buying and selling, consumer desire, and media influence with caste and communal fragmentation. The final questions direct the reader towards alternatives to the market order, social struggle, and change founded on reason. Research-based criticism can also debate new opportunities generated by markets; the primary text's allegiance to exploited people, however, is explicit.

5. Integrated Critical Assessment

5.1 Distinctive Achievements of the Collection

The principal success of Agni-Shikha lies in placing the concerns of marginalised people at the centre of literary language, while poetry confronts the prejudices, inertia, and institutional hypocrisy of its own cultural community. The collection can be read simultaneously as a record of Maithili linguistic rights, a people's history of Mithila's geography, a forceful instance of political satire, and a laboratory of modern free verse.

5.2 The Tension between Experience and Declaration

When poems present concrete experiences—drought, floods, flatbread made from finger millet, school fees, a waiting mother, bus stops, or workers' bodies—the text acquires particular density. When multiple political slogans, insulting adjectives, or violent symbols accumulate in a single line, the poetry sometimes becomes excessively declaratory. Yet this tension is inseparable from the poet's perception of his time; it must not simply be dismissed but understood in its causes and workings.

5.3 Solidarity with the People and the Limits of Representation

The poet stands unequivocally with workers, women, farmers, students, and disadvantaged communities. Yet not all these figures speak equally in their own voices. Satirical references to women's bodies or caste names call for examination to determine whether a language opposed to exploitation sometimes reproduces inherited terms of humiliation. This question cannot be neglected in a serious assessment of people's literature.

5.4 The Text's Relationship with History

References to Indira, the constitutional movement for linguistic recognition, Naxalites, violence in Gujarat, political scandals, and liberalisation increase the collection's historical significance. But a poem is not

a primary historical archive; it is an artistic reconstitution of historical experience. Verifying dates, legal circumstances, and factual claims requires separate research into government records, independent historical documents, and contemporary reporting.

5.5 Dialogue with Rajkamal and Modern Maithili Poetry

Presenting Rajkamal Chaudhary in 'Calcutta and Rajkamal' as a rebel committed to innovation suggests a dialogue within literary tradition. External studies of Rajkamal's modernism emphasise his multilingual practice and experimentation, but this does not mean that these studies automatically prove the judgments voiced by the poet in Agni-Shikha. Mallick's poem remains the primary evidence.

6. Conclusion

In Agni-Shikha, poetry committed to ordinary people develops an extensive critical framework encompassing Mithila's linguistic movement, political discontent, caste, hunger, labour, women's experiences, cultural hypocrisy, and inequalities produced by market ideology. The poems oppose lifeless praise and passive cultural pride. The poet champions the people's knowledge, or lokaveda, while also questioning the established order within it. This contradiction is the source of much of the collection's vitality.

Reading all fifty-five poems makes clear that 'fire' does not invariably signify bloodshed. More often, it stands for the heat of consciousness, self-criticism, dissent from injustice, and the possibility of renewal. Even when the poetry becomes didactic or severe, the human dignity of the people remains its fundamental concern. The book should therefore not be read merely as a collection of political slogans but as a multidimensional literary document of struggles over language, power, and popular life in modern Maithili poetry.

Appendix: All 55 Poems, Original Pages, and Order of the Contents

The sequence follows the fifty entries in the original 'Order of Poems'. Where an entry contains two distinct poems, both are attached to that one original entry number. Composite titles in the original contents are treated here as separate poems.

Five entries in the original sequence contain two separate poems each: entry 6 ('Evening'/'The Maithil Woman'), 7 ('Snake'/'Master Sahib'), 8 ('The Maithili Movement'/'Mini Girl'), 24 ('War'/'Unconquerable'), and 25 ('Dynamism'/'The State of Affairs').

Poem	Original entry	Title	Original page(s)
1	1	From the City to the Village	9–11
2	2	A Morsel of Flesh	12–13
3	3	A Box of Revolution	14–15
4	4	O My Elders, Be Still	16–17

Poem	Original entry	Title	Original page(s)
5	5	Bengal Bandh	18–19
6	6	Evening	20
7	6	The Maithil Woman	20
8	7	Snake	21
9	7	Master Sahib	21
10	8	The Maithili Movement	22
11	8	Mini Girl	22
12	9	My Dear Indira	23–24
13	10	In the Courtyard of Independence	25–26
14	11	Kirtan	27–28
15	12	Cancer	29–30
16	13	The Prayer Room	31–32
17	14	Among Four Hundred Thousand Monkeys	33–34
18	15	In the Name of Our Folk Knowledge	35–39
19	16	Naxalite	40–41
20	17	Electric Pressure	42–44
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24	21	The Drama of Being Thrust into Yet Another Hell	57–58
25	22	Playing with a Gun against a Yelping Dog	59–61
26	23	Vishnuryonim	62
27	24	War	63
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29	25	Dynamism	64
30	25	The State of Affairs	64
31	26	To an Impotent Leader	65–66
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CHAPTER 2 • THE LITERATURE OF VIRENDRA MALLICK

Athato Kavya Jijnasa

A study of 46 poems • Nature, globalisation, the mother tongue, and poetry's self-examination

Complete list of poems based on the original table of contents

No.	Poem	Original page(s)	Principal theme
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3	Shyama Sundari	13	Railway movement, nature
4	An Adivasi Home	14	Adivasi communities, home
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No.	Poem	Original page(s)	Principal theme
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7	Blessed Are the Waters of the Brahmani River	22–26	River, environment
8	There Was Once a Village of Mine	27–32	Village, memory
9	Wandering Like a Stray	33–36	Festival, consumerism
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No.	Poem	Original page(s)	Principal theme
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28	There Is No Other Alternative	77–78	Political alternatives
29	I.Q.	79	Education, society
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34	Mother Tongue	86	Mother tongue, education
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38	Message of the Age	92	Historical consciousness, struggle
39	Ta-Ta! Bye-Bye!	93–95	Women, modernity
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46	Stop the Drama, Sir	110–111	Civic satire

No.	Poem	Original page(s)	Principal theme
6			

This collection by Virendra Mallick comprises forty-six poems. Alongside an interpretation of each poem, the discussion considers nature, social resistance, linguistic rights, and questions concerning contemporary civilisation.

Principal Questions in the Collection's Poetic World

Poetry, Life, and Ethical Commitment

In the title poem, 'Athato Kavya Jijnasa', poetry is neither a mere object of entertainment nor an ornamental marvel; it is a sensibility essential to life. Fields, workers, justice, words, the vitality of language, and the deprivation of ordinary people become poetry's field of subject matter. 'Poetry Ready for Sale' presents an inversion of these values: the fear that poetry itself may become merchandise. 'Discourse on Speech' and 'Thus Spoke Poetry' further extend this self-examination of writing. Read together, these four works clarify the poet's philosophy of poetry: it should remove the veil of social untruth without itself dissolving into commercial prestige or mere sermonising.

The Ironies of Democracy, Power, and Public Language

'A Message Has Arrived from Patna', 'Election! Election!', 'He Will Enjoy Himself! He Will Rule!', 'Rail! Rail!', 'The Purana of Leaders', 'Dance! Democracy, Dance!', 'There Is No Other Alternative', and 'Inside and Outside' repeatedly test structures of authority, advertising, government, corruption, and dynastic tendencies. The distance between democracy's vocabulary and the people's experience is the chief tension here. Onomatopoeic titles, exclamations, repetition, and direct address transform the theatricality of public speeches, election slogans, and civic debate into poetry. Yet the poems' directness is both their strength and their risk: many lines become declarations of ideas.

The Market, Consumerism, and Globalisation

'India Shining', 'The Great Hero's Journey through the Forest', 'Language Standing in the Marketplace', 'Poetry Ready for Sale', 'The Market', and 'Globalisation' place criticism of consumer society at their centre. Behind the glitter of development they reveal inequality, cultural commodification, insecurity among workers, and the utilitarian devaluation of language. For the poet, the market is not merely a place for buying and selling; it is a framework of social judgment in which profit rather than humanity becomes the measure of value. The clash between the glittering title 'India Shining' and the poem's scenes of labour rooted in the material world is an effective technique.

Village, Forest, River, and a Changing Ecology

'The Ashoka Tree', 'The Babool Tree', 'Shyama Sundari', 'An Adivasi Home', 'Blessed Are the Waters of the Brahmani River', 'There Was Once a Village of Mine', and 'Wandering Like a Stray' move beyond conventional descriptions of natural beauty. Felled trees, train windows, displaced settlements, pollution, the destruction of forests, the memory of rivers, and chaotic collective scenes together form a record of a changing earth. Several poems begin with small scenes before developing into extended social narratives. This expansion allows a reading of the connections between natural imagery and structures of power.

Language, Mother Tongue, and Cultural Identity

'Maithili Barni', 'Mother Tongue', 'Bhola Babu', and 'Language Standing in the Marketplace' suggest that language is not simply an instrument of communication but a site of generational memory and collective self-respect. The ascendancy of English, educational policy, publishing prestige, and pressures surrounding linguistic choices preoccupy the poet. The brief sections of 'Maithili Barni' create an experience of regional life through separate scenes. 'Bhola Babu' marks public awakening to the mother tongue through a particular personality. In this poetic vision, love for Maithili acquires political meaning rather than remaining mere sentimental attachment.

Class, Caste, Adivasi Communities, and the Dispossessed

The poet calls for reading social inequality at two levels: intimate personal suffering and structural injustice. In 'An Adivasi Home', natural surroundings coexist with deprivation; in 'Playing with Poetry on a Heap of Gunpowder', class consciousness, violence, displacement, and resistance enter complex relationships. 'There Is No Other Alternative' portrays the unbearable consequences of hunger and political inaction. When the poet speaks on behalf of the dispossessed, the critic must also observe that these figures often lack extended voices of their own, appearing instead within the poet's ethical pronouncements. Such questioning does not diminish the importance of the collection; it makes its reading more responsible.

Religion, Ritualism, and Ethical Judgment

'Shankaracharya', 'Ritualism', 'The Wheel of Time', and 'Oh, What a World! Oh, What a World!' criticise religious authority, arrogance, deception, and ethical decline more than religion as such. The poet investigates the relationship between action and conduct. 'Ritualism' portrays the absence of high standards and contradictions enacted in the names of education and industry; 'The Wheel of Time' distrusts a linear doctrine of progress. It would be inappropriate to find in these texts a rejection of all forms of belief. Their essential targets are the political misuse of religious symbols and insensitivity to human suffering.

Women's Experience and Social Inequality

'Ta-Ta! Bye-Bye!' stages tensions among modernity, the body, education, respect for women, and patriarchal perception. The living conception of the

river in 'Blessed Are the Waters of the Brahmani River' and the intervention against women's inequality in 'Stop the Drama, Sir' broaden the discussion. The poet's sympathy lies with women's dignity, yet some representations may turn women into symbols of social debate rather than autonomous narrators; that critical caution is indispensable.

Literary Memory and the Tradition of People's Poets

'Soldier of the Pen: Rajkamal', 'Bhola Babu', 'Discourse on Speech', and the title poem establish a self-dialogue with literary tradition. Rajkamal's creativity, Bhola Babu's contributions to language, memories of earlier poetry, and the contemporary poet's predicament converge as subjects of criticism. The combination of the classical 'athato' and modern colloquial speech is distinctive to this poetic world. The poet refuses to detach poetic form from humanity and social justice.

Linguistic Craft: Invocation, Repetition, and Multilayered Vocabulary

Alongside fundamental Maithili grammar and vernacular speech, the collection employs Sanskrit-derived vocabulary, political expressions borrowed through Hindi, English-inflected titles ('I.Q.', 'India Shining', 'Intolerance', 'Dance! Democracy, Dance!'), and modern technical and social terminology. This combination is no simple linguistic deviation: the poems' social world is itself multilingual. Forms such as 'achhi', 'san', 'ken', 'bha', 'jakan', 'kakaro', and 'muda' establish the underlying Maithili idiom. Repeated phrases, satirical forms of address, disrupted rhythms, interrogative utterances, and catalogues of accusations produce a kind of poetry suited to a public platform. Lyrical miniatures and extended free verse coexist.

Contradictions and Artistic Achievements

The collection's major virtues are its unequivocal solidarity with ordinary people, its courageous engagement with contemporary subjects, and its ease of movement between language and nature. The brief nature poems offer restrained imagery; long social poems develop rapid utterance; satirical compositions evoke the cadence of slogans. There are limits, too: the poet often names issues so directly that the reader may have less room for discovery, while recurrent terms such as 'market', 'corruption', 'development', and 'imperialism' sometimes make the voices of individual poems resemble one another. Nevertheless, the diversity of contexts and tonal elements prevents the collection from becoming a single political manifesto.

Critical Study, Poem by Poem

1. The Ashoka Tree

Original page: 11 | Principal theme: Nature, visual scene

The poem opens with a scene of greenery before a dak bungalow, glittering water, a boundary wall, and a young woman wearing a 'swimming suit'. The ashoka tree standing in the middle is nature's silent presence. On one side lies the modern world of decoration and luxury; on the other, a surviving tree. In

this brief picture, the poet's eye fills a public scene with social significance. The tree's name also sounds a subtle note of cultural memory.

Brevity is the poem's chief formal quality. It does not deliver an extended political argument but selects a single scene. Readers must consider for themselves the relationship between the tree's steadfast presence and the exhibition of human consumption. That the collection opens with such a restrained image of nature is significant, for later poems connect nature with the much larger questions of market ideology, inequality, and destruction.

2. The Babool Tree

Original page: 12 | Principal theme: Nature, endurance

The rough, weathered body of a babool tree, its thin broken branches, its thorns, and the sky with pigeons create an image of difficult vitality. Though it has neither flowers nor fruit, the tree remains standing; the harshness of time is inscribed upon its body. A leaf here, a flower there, an occasional trace: instead of conventional nature appreciation, these become memories of struggle.

Read beside 'The Ashoka Tree', the poem reveals contrasts between greenness and barrenness, a landscaped enclosure and neglected life. The poet does not simply pronounce the babool ugly; he sketches the contours of its resistant existence. Short descriptive lines and visually oriented language give the poem restraint.

3. Shyama Sundari

Original page: 13 | Principal theme: Railway movement, nature

Dark hills visible from a train window, distant expanses of greenery, trees left behind, and repeatedly changing scenes form the basis of the poem. The name 'Shyama Sundari' personifies the hills as a newly married woman who appears shyly and fleetingly. A delicate beauty emerges from the difference between the train's movement and the stillness of natural objects.

The moving field of vision is important to the poem. The window does not offer entry into nature; it frames nature as something seen from a distance. Awareness of this distance is connected with the collection's subsequent treatment of displacement from villages. The flowing, unforced lines contain affectionate similes; when the title's aesthetic possibilities are read alongside other social themes, the range of the poet's experience becomes apparent.

4. An Adivasi Home

Original page: 14 | Principal theme: Adivasi communities, home

A mountain hollow, a clear blue sky, fragments of light, a distant chasm, the dry leaves of high summer, and a momentary flash of lightning produce a picture of an Adivasi settlement. Closeness to nature and the dilapidation of the dwelling occupy the same scene; the poet does not equate natural beauty with complete happiness.

The poem's social meaning resides in its restrained structure. Though it describes deprivation, it does not reduce the people to mere objects of pity; it presents their existence through place, season, and the components of everyday life. Critically, one should observe that the Adivasi community does not speak at length in its own voice here: the poet works through an external, visually sensitive perspective. That limit is central to testing the poem's realist implications.

5. A Message Has Arrived from Patna

Original pages: 15–17 | Principal theme: Power, dialogue

The opening statement—about the breakdown of human fellowship, the erosion of class consciousness, and the expansion of self-interest in place of affectionate relationships—identifies a crisis of metropolitan political consciousness. Patna is not merely a geographical reference but a sign of the centres of power and communication. The poem gradually moves from private life towards the literary world and public struggle.

This long free-verse composition employs repetition, dramatic turns, and accusatory sentences. An irony emerges between the 'dialogue' of the title and the description of a society unable to converse. The poet asks what role poetry can retain where a society has stopped listening to its own people. At times the rhythm approaches political oratory, but that very oratorical quality captures an unsettled historical moment.

6. Playing with Poetry on a Heap of Gunpowder

Original pages: 18–21 | Principal theme: Violence, resistance

The poem opens with self-questioning: for what offence am I suffering punishment, what burden of a curse from an earlier birth do I carry, and in what deserted terrain have I become trapped? Fields, forests, caste and class divisions, urbanisation, and exploitation then accumulate as scenes. The 'heap of gunpowder' is the smouldering foundation of a violent society; to play with poetry upon it suggests the moral courage required to remain alive.

In this long composition, the 'I' comes to represent not only an individual but the suppressed consciousness of society. Nature, home, labour, rights, and social injustice are interwoven. The extended movement of free verse brings personal testimony and collective utterance together. Its strength is its insistence that poetry remain a voice amid fear; its artistic risk is that the sheer abundance of subjects sometimes turns images into a catalogue.

7. Blessed Are the Waters of the Brahmani River

Original pages: 22–26 | Principal theme: River, environment

The Brahmani River's waters, feet immersed in them, ripples, contact with water, and ever-renewed sensations constitute the poem's experiential centre. The river is not merely a natural resource: it becomes a symbol of the body, memory, thirst, the flow of life, and the mutual creativity of women and men. The experience of water's sacredness arises not from fixed ritual but from direct bodily and sensory experience.

The poem is comparatively long and employs an undulating syntax corresponding to the movement of water. Through the river, the poet articulates an idea of the rebirth of natural energy. In contrast to the small scene of 'The Ashoka Tree', nature here becomes a philosophy of the entirety of experience. Yet the images should not simply be categorised as mysticism; they deserve to be related to the social importance of the natural world.

8. There Was Once a Village of Mine

Original pages: 27–32 | Principal theme: Village, memory

'There Was Once a Village of Mine' is a moving declaration of memory. The family homestead, mango and bakain trees, neem, the grandfather, tastes associated with fairs, games, folk festivals, neighbours, and countless village scenes emerge in succession. Against them, the present shows how the village's identity, traditions, and social relationships have changed. The word 'was' becomes the poem's governing consciousness of time.

This is not merely a celebration of a sweet past but a social elegy for a damaged communal life. Tensions in caste relationships, newer political practices, the decline of linguistic culture, and changing lifestyles disclose the harsher side behind nostalgia. The long catalogue sometimes creates intimacy and intensity, sometimes demands patience from the reader. Nevertheless, the poem is important for the cultural study of the modern Maithil village.

9. Wandering Like a Stray

Original pages: 33–36 | Principal theme: Festival, consumerism

Decorated pandals, Durga Puja, uncontrolled crowds, stages, fashion, 'challenges', 'duplicates', and newly consumerist display create an image of restless masses. The experience of 'wandering like a stray' in the title metaphorically figures society's loss of direction: people keep moving, but the connections between movement and purpose have broken down.

The fragmentary arrangement of different scenes imitates the clamour of urban festivals. When religious celebration, entertainment, stage culture, and commerce become a single spectacle, the poet asks where human judgment remains. The poem succeeds in its multivoiced language; its limitation is that the poet's objections to the cultural scene sometimes reduce broad social distinctions to one general fault.

10. Maithili Barni

Original pages: 37–39 | Principal theme: Vignettes, nature

This poem is composed of several numbered miniature sections. Lamps, the heart, leaves and falling leaves, water, skeletal trees, silence, and the changing forms of nature create a sequence of small scenes. Each section resembles a vignette; meaning is communicated through suggestion and pauses more than through full exposition.

The title 'Barni' draws the reader towards colours of experience and differing shades of nature. In formal terms, the poem differs radically from

the collection's extended political and oratorical passages. Its extremely short lines, sparse words, and unspoken meanings invite a reading as a sequence of independent miniatures or minute images. The experiment is important evidence of the collection's expressive diversity.

11. The Great Hero's Journey through the Forest

Original pages: 40–43 | Principal theme: Politics, capital

Democracy, republican government, official publicity, currency, trade, foreign corporations, and the immense network of capital form the poem's background. The ironic use of 'great hero' critiques the heroic image manufactured by those in power; the 'journey through the forest' suggests social darkness, lost direction, and a wilderness of uncontrolled capital amid supposed progress.

The poem places political economics and publicity machinery in one landscape. The lack of resources among ordinary people and governmental mismanagement confront public pronouncements of prosperity. Long lines and densely accumulated names of things make its satire sharp. The accusations should not be treated as substitutes for historical statistics: they are above all a poetic indictment based on social experience.

12. India Shining

Original pages: 44–46 | Principal theme: Satire of development

Industrialisation, globalisation, consumer markets, and the sharp divide between workers and the poor on one side and wealthy groups on the other lie at the poem's centre. Behind the gleaming image of 'shining' appear hunger, unemployment, loss, and human devastation. The advertising language of the English title and the poem's social inequalities create opposing meanings.

The principal satirical technique is to confront the conventional vocabulary of 'progress' with concrete experience. The poet does not accept glitter as the whole truth. Economic terminology adds ideological rigour, yet the pain of the poem is most intense in the lines closest to a human voice. It is useful to read this composition alongside 'Accounts' and 'The Market'.

13. Shankaracharya

Original pages: 47–48 | Principal theme: Religion, conduct

Against a background of unrest across the country, economic insecurity, unemployment, political self-interest, and growing frenzy in religion's name, this poem questions the conduct of spiritual leadership. The title invokes a historical and cultural designation, but the world depicted reveals a gulf between religious eminence and responsibility towards humanity.

The poet targets the political exploitation of unquestioning devotion and structures of prestige alienated from popular suffering. Through lists, questions, and ethical objections, the poem subjects religious authority to a social examination. It would be premature to read it as an attack on all

spirituality; its core question is how far the proclaimers of lofty ideals are responsible to society's suffering.

14. Oh, What a World! Oh, What a World!

Original pages: 49–50 | Principal theme: Vernacular satire

The poem opens with an exclamation from popular speech. Heaps of lies, scattered relationships, casteism, borrowed Marxist ideas, the image of Durga, and public deception combine in the poet's experience of contradictions everywhere. The recurring cry 'Oh, what a world!' conveys surprise, anguish, and satire at once.

The composition follows a sequence of indignation more than one of logical argument. Its exclamation returns like the refrain of a folk song, bringing the sound of a popular stage to the reader. In parallel, it asks where human trust can rest when religion, ideology, and justice survive only as names. The risk of generalisation deserves attention alongside the poem's cutting force.

15. Ritualism

Original pages: 51–52 | Principal theme: Religion, action

The distance between high ideals of conduct and actual behaviour forms the poem's basic opposition. Education, industry, corruption, exploitation, terror, wrongdoing, and human self-interest are connected to the discussion of religious practice. 'Ritualism' signifies not only rites of worship but also social activity without ethical consequences.

The poem reflects upon cycles of cause and effect: if education concerning action becomes a hollow label, character does not develop. Its lines favour direct statement over imagery, and social diagnosis predominates. The placement of this poem immediately before 'The Wheel of Time' matters because the next composition raises wider questions about the relationship between time and action.

16. The Wheel of Time

Original pages: 53–54 | Principal theme: Time, judgment

The poem calls for abandoning the inertia of the past and building the future through action in the present, while criticising false fatalism, the opposition between heaven and hell, and hollow reasoning. The movement of time becomes evidence against superstition. The poet brings the familiar spiritual suggestion of the 'wheel of time' into the realm of rational thought and social action.

Brief declarative lines carry the movement of ideas. Time is not simply an immutable cycle of destiny but also offers the possibility of human intervention. The poem constructs a counterpoint to 'Ritualism': action in place of ritual, judgment in place of blind belief. Although its rational argument makes the meaning unusually direct, the poem expresses the collection's ethical centre at the level of historical consciousness.

17. Athato Kavya Jijnasa

Original pages: 55–57 | Principal theme: Philosophy of poetry

The title poem asks a direct question: where should poetry be heard? Its answer is: in life, in hunger, in the vital breath of language and words, and on the side of unemployed people, workers, farmers, and those denied justice. The colours of fields, grain and ears of wheat, the posture of the rich and the gait of the poor—all these social images appear in a single work.

The philosophical seriousness of 'athato' and poetry's pledge to ordinary people combine to form the collection's poetics. The poem attempts to define itself, but locates the value of words in social usefulness rather than the poet's personal ambition. Read with 'Poetry Ready for Sale' and 'Thus Spoke Poetry', the oppositions between value and exchange and between creative writing and publicity become particularly clear.

18. Accounts

Original pages: 58–60 | Principal theme: Development, accountability

The work is set against government claims about development, pride in governance, announcements of awards, development statistics, and public publicity. The poet demands an accounting between glittering speeches and the experience of ordinary people. 'Accounts' is not merely a term from bookkeeping but an ethical measure of democratic accountability.

Repetition of administrative language becomes mocking. To what extent do the achievements proclaimed through advertisements and honours actually enter people's lives? That is the fundamental question. The optimistic publicity of 'India Shining' becomes the subject of scrutiny in this poem. Its strength lies in disclosing contradictions within official speech; its limitation is a relative scarcity of restrained visual imagery.

19. Election! Election!

Original pages: 61–62 | Principal theme: Elections, slogans

The election marketplace returning after five years, prominent politicians rising upon slender supports, colourful vehicles travelling from village to village, folded hands, promises showered upon every home, and a temporary trade in trust become the ironies of democracy's festival. The title's repetition makes the clamour of election publicity audible.

The poem reveals a contradiction between the fleeting intimacy of politicians and voters and their enduring separation. Before elections the people become important, but their expectations may go unheard once the results are known. The rhythm of vernacular speech, satirical inventories, and dramatic turns give the work a theatrical effect. It does not wholly reject democracy but asks how democracy may be made meaningful.

20. Language Standing in the Marketplace

Original pages: 63–64 | Principal theme: Language, the market

The poem directly addresses the danger that language may become an advertising instrument and a commodity for profit. The intimacy of linguistic exchange declines, the medium of communication becomes a commercial sign, and the roles of electronic and print media become contentious. The title personifies language as a human being standing in the market, and this image conveys profound insecurity.

Read alongside 'Mother Tongue' and 'Globalisation', the poem raises questions of the political economy of language. In whose hands is language? Who profits from it? Where can its creative value survive? The poet does not fully answer these questions but defends the independent importance of the people's language. The image of buying and selling words is exceptionally suggestive.

21. He Will Enjoy Himself! He Will Rule!

Original pages: 65–66 | Principal theme: Government, parliamentarianism

The shameless self-interest of the political class, the shelter of professed secularism, the pleasures of office, parliament's self-absorbed behaviour, and the humiliation of ordinary people are the poem's central concerns. The repeated 'he' in the title points towards the ruling class; in contrast, the 'we', or the people, remains silent yet present.

The poem is written in an accusatory tone, with repetition and rhyme intensifying the rhythm of popular anger. Its negative image of parliamentary conduct clashes with democratic values. The poet exposes the irony of pursuing self-interest in the name of national welfare. Criticism must nevertheless remember that the composition records the political reaction of a particular poetic voice, not an independently verified sociological account of every legislator or institution.

22. Rail! Rail!

Original pages: 67–68 | Principal theme: Democracy, spectacle

Competition between parties in parliament, the appetite for office, corruption, slogans about women's rights, policy questions, and public disillusionment supply the poem's main material. Unlike an ordinary description of a railway train, the title 'Rail' suggests the noise and motion of running about, pushing, and ceaseless activity in parliament.

Public issues crowd irregularly into line after line. This form deliberately imitates political congestion. Where 'Election! Election!' portrays the electoral stage, 'Rail! Rail!' concentrates on disintegration inside a representative institution. The poem demands meaningful work in the public interest, but its direct accusations sometimes restrict the development of metaphor.

23. The Purana of Leaders

Original pages: 69–70 | Principal theme: Satire, politicians

Short, forceful lines such as 'Ministers, fixers, leaders, thieves' form the poem's central rhythm. Brief sections on corrupt officials, police, electoral

opportunism, exploitation, oppression of women, and the dominance of criminals give the word 'purana' a satirical new meaning. In place of a traditional grand narrative, we encounter a compilation of modern political vices.

Both metaphor and poetic arrangement are distinctive: the two-line units resemble folk sayings or caustic aphorisms. Each section delivers an independent blow, but together they reveal the persistent futility of the established order. Their concision is entirely unlike the expansiveness of 'The Great Hero's Journey through the Forest'. The immediate satirical impact is considerable, although fine distinctions among social complexities receive relatively little attention.

24. Poetry Ready for Sale

Original pages: 71–72 | Principal theme: Literature, commodification

Taking 'Poetry is being sold in the marketplace' as its premise, this composition offers a fierce criticism of the commodification of creativity. When poems of different colours, shapes, and emotions become merchandise, the relationship between literary sensibility and prestige changes. Poetry, which ought to speak truths about human sorrow and happiness, faces the danger of becoming an exhibition object within consumer society.

The poem's most effective image is the poetry market. It provides an inverse story to the ideal set out in 'Athato Kavya Jijnasa'. If a writer who gives voice to social suffering becomes trapped in the prices of publication, praise, and commercial exchange, how much of poetry's original purpose can survive? The poet compels listeners and readers to consider the answer. The satire is direct and its possibilities for self-criticism are extensive.

25. Keep One Foot Always on the Earth

Original pages: 73–74 | Principal theme: Soil, ostentation

Clothing, celebrities, film stars, unreal spectacles, empty glitter, wasteful wedding celebrations, and contradictions in social lifestyles appear in this poem. The title makes an ethical appeal not to sever one's connection with life's ground. 'Earth' signifies not only geography but labour, practical judgment, and the realities of ordinary people.

Its criticism of ostentation sometimes leaps from one subject to another. The fragmented construction places many incongruous scenes of modern public life together. Its powerful message is that ambition and prestige should remain connected to a human foundation. At times the logical bridges between examples are weak, but the unity supplied by the title gives them a common ethical centre.

26. In the Middle of the Road

Original page: 75 | Principal theme: Ordinary people, hunger

An ordinary person standing in the middle of a road, smoke rising everywhere, hunger, unemployment, public life as performance, and political

agitation form the poem's centre. The road symbolises democratic public space; the helplessness of the person standing in its middle becomes an image of the neglect of the people as a whole.

The poem shows a connection between material deprivation and estrangement from public institutions. Directional words—north, south, east, west—convey the ubiquity of the problem. Short lines and direct statements make the work readily communicable. Its great question is how far the true value of democracy can be measured from the voice of the person standing in the road.

27. Dance! Democracy, Dance!

Original page: 76 | Principal theme: Democracy, spectacle

The repeated demand to 'dance' is an auditory image satirising the transformation of democratic public life into theatre. Amid injustice, displays of official power, exploitation of women, corruption, and the noise of the masses, democracy seems to perform a dance. The combination of the English word 'democracy' with Maithili- and Hindi-inflected utterances exposes contradictions in modern political speech.

Repetition like a song's refrain intensifies the satire. Democracy here is not an ideal but a spectacle being sold upon a stage. Unlike several related political poems, this work assumes the form of an audible performance: power itself becomes a drama. The poet's dissent is not indifference towards democratic values but a demand for genuinely democratic conduct.

28. There Is No Other Alternative

Original pages: 77–78 | Principal theme: Political alternatives

Amid the country's deterioration, the anguish of the poor, hunger and thirst, weak leadership, corrupt institutions, and the opportunism of parties, the people remain deprived. The title sounds like a declaration of despair, but the poem also insists on the necessity of changing the system. The supposed absence of alternatives can become a critique of the artificial compulsion invoked in political speeches.

Ethical anguish dominates the composition. The underlying question reaches the reader: if people have been deceived in their hopes and aspirations, is this a time to remain inactive? Following 'Election!' and 'Dance! Democracy, Dance!', this poem moves the crisis beyond electoral scenes to the level of social alternatives.

29. I.Q.

Original page: 79 | Principal theme: Education, society

Poverty, hungry children, the education system, society's ethical direction, and the responsibilities of the educated class feature in this poem. The title invoking the modern intelligence quotient, 'I.Q.', clashes with the practical crises of ordinary people. What is the social purpose of knowledge if education

cannot comprehend hunger and human injustice? That is its fundamental question.

The English title symbolises a method of measuring intelligence, whereas the subject addresses elementary values of life. Satire arises from the contrast. The poet does not simply reject technical expertise; he advocates the social responsibility of knowledge. Lines relating to mentors, teachers, and youth place educational thinking on an ethical foundation.

30. Partner

Original page: 80 | Principal theme: Partnership, power

The familiar address of friendship and partnership gradually becomes a satire of global power relations. References to a 'Kamasutra bed-partner', America, and opportunism attack the commercial meaning acquired by relationships. 'Partner' moves from private life to signify alliances within political economy.

The poem's style is conversational, ironic, and multilayered. Its underlying question concerns whom one should stand beside in a social crisis and how far compromises with others can remain ethical. It is interconnected with 'India Shining' and 'Globalisation', since all three are concerned with the intrusion of the market into life.

31. In the Name of One's Darling

Original pages: 81–82 | Principal theme: Dynasticism, family

Building a chain of names—Aditya, Anand, Sarvanand, Dipit, Dinesh, and others—the poet questions attachment to one's 'darling', favouritism towards children, and the pursuit of fame and wealth. The proliferation of names begins as a kind of game, but then reveals family ambition, social prestige, and the distribution of resources.

The poem's formal device is enumeration. The sequence of ordinary family names discloses social prejudice and the political shadow of dynastic descent. Here one can see the smaller, domestic form of the family-centred political structures found in 'He Will Enjoy Himself!' and 'Inside and Outside'. There is a danger of generalisation from a few names, but the title's domestic familiarity lends the satire its sting.

32. Intolerance

Original pages: 83–84 | Principal theme: Tolerance, society

Old and younger generations, changing social behaviour, manners of speech, displays of clothing, new orthodoxies in the name of dissent, injustice, and the loss of patience form the poem's subjects. The title adopts a contemporary English term of debate, but the poet asks whether tolerance is merely a slogan or a value practised in daily life.

The poem touches upon tensions among disagreement, social discipline, and human respect. Its lines suggest a diminishing ability to listen to one another and a tendency to make political judgments on outward appearances.

It would not be reasonable automatically to treat changing fashion or younger people's conduct as ethical decline; the poem's force lies in its experience of intolerance, which merits wider reflection.

33. Bullets and Guns

Original page: 85 | Principal theme: Violence, firearms

Smoke over village and city, bullets and guns, endangered green trees, grief in parliament, the helplessness of police, and the disturbed condition of young people suggest the normalisation of violence. The direct naming of weapons in the title establishes an atmosphere of fear. The poem attacks the gulf between the security of life and democratic institutions.

This is an extremely concise composition. It connects the terror of ordinary life, the state's ineffectiveness, and the insecurity of future generations in very few words. The expansive fear of 'Playing with Poetry on a Heap of Gunpowder' is here condensed into a sharp aphoristic statement. Its economy of form distinguishes the poem from the longer political compositions.

34. Mother Tongue

Original page: 86 | Principal theme: Mother tongue, education

The burden of books and exercise books, pressure from the education system, the dominance of English, neglect of regional languages, and fear of cultural destruction are the central concerns of 'Mother Tongue'. The poem argues that when education is separated from the emotional world of one's language, the foundations of intimate knowledge weaken. The mother tongue is not simply another subject but the underlying ground of family, culture, and memory.

The poet calls for change in education and everyday practice to protect the language. He criticises the elevation of one language alone by pushing regional languages aside. The market pressure in 'Language Standing in the Marketplace', the constructive history of linguistic activism in 'Bhola Babu', and the practical problem of education in this poem together form a comprehensive triangle of linguistic debate.

35. A Rented House

Original page: 87 | Principal theme: Life, transience

The world is a rented house, people are its tenants, everything is temporary, and the ultimate landlord is omnipresent: this compressed metaphor constitutes the entire poem. Away from the clamour of political satire, the poet considers life's impermanence and the illusion of ownership.

The poem's striking feature is its minimal length. The simplicity of its sentences conveys the whole sense that nothing remains permanently in one place. This work serves as a spiritual and symbolic pause amid extensive social criticism. In the context of the many poems that question property and power, the metaphor of the 'landlord' also acquires more complex significance.

36. The Market

Original page: 88 | Principal theme: Markets, capital

India is presented as a vast marketplace, people as customers, foreign companies as powerful merchants, and communities as bonded participants. Both goods and desires are caught within the logic of exchange. The market is gaining power not only over commodities but over the decisions people make about their lives.

Despite its brevity, the poem is central to the collection's economic satire. What many other poems explain through extensive examples, 'The Market' condenses almost into an aphorism. 'India Shining', 'Language Standing in the Marketplace', and 'Globalisation' elaborate its argument. 'Poetry Ready for Sale' reveals the effects of the same logic of exchange upon culture.

37. Globalisation

Original pages: 89–91 | Principal theme: Globalisation

Globalisation, industry, trade, customs, food, and rapid changes in the younger generation's lifestyle constitute the poem's principal material. The material culture of one country enters another and alters the marks of local life. Mixtures of languages and behaviours are visible expressions of this historical process.

Modern vocabulary itself becomes material for criticism. The poet refuses to equate global connections with prosperity alone, questioning them in terms of balances of power, local production, culture, and social equality. The poem does not, however, establish through explicit evidence that all forms of international contact are unequal. Its target is globalisation's dominating aspect.

38. Message of the Age

Original page: 92 | Principal theme: Historical consciousness, struggle

Moving beyond memories of times past, the poem attempts to direct the present towards a challenging future. The people are suffering, society has lost direction, and the repetition of history has become oppressive; in these circumstances, collective struggle and a commitment to social change are deemed necessary.

The poem is not merely didactic but an inspiration to collective action. The suggestion that 'our land is not barren; recognise its strength of spirit' awakens possibility rather than despair. It is a constructive response to the consciousness of time in 'The Wheel of Time': understanding the past is meaningful only when followed by action directed towards the future. The exhortatory voice is effective despite the relatively straightforward free verse.

39. Ta-Ta! Bye-Bye!

Original pages: 93–95 | Principal theme: Women, modernity

Relations between women and men, the spread of education, outward modernity, patriarchal pressure, and women's dignity feature in this poem.

'Ta-Ta! Bye-Bye!' initially suggests a speaker bidding farewell to an ending relationship or era, but the following lines reveal an ongoing conflict between inherited values and modern ostentation.

The poem upholds respect for women yet simultaneously expresses suspicion towards new public displays of lifestyle. Its reading is therefore complex: women's freedom, social conventions, and modernity cannot all be weighed by the same measure. The work's contribution is to bring questions of women's experience into public debate; critics should leave its culturally inherited assumptions open to examination.

40. Bhola Babu

Original pages: 96–97 | Principal theme: Service to Maithili

'Bhola Babu' praises a promoter of the mother tongue, a defender of social consciousness, a participant in public awakening for Mithila and Maithili, and a figure associated with literary institutions. Through a particular person, the poem illuminates the memory of the linguistic movement and the importance of collective labour.

Its tone differs from the other fiercely political poems: respect, gratitude, and awareness of a cultural debt dominate. Where 'Mother Tongue' exposes a crisis, 'Bhola Babu' presents the possibility of protecting the language through human action. A feature of biographical verse is its enumeration of names and deeds; independent sources are required to verify the factual life, but within the poem the figure symbolises service to Maithili.

41. Soldier of the Pen: Rajkamal

Original page: 98 | Principal theme: Literary memory

This poem is a remembrance of Rajkamal Chaudhary marked by homage and intellectual affinity. His memory is presented through the figures of a rebellious writer, a portrayer of women's suffering, an experimental artist of fiction and poetry, and a fearless poetic voice. The 'soldier of the pen' in the title gives the writer's work an ethical dimension of struggle.

References to Rajkamal's works and examples of conflicting values build this composition of memory. It is one poet's poetic assessment of another, not a substitute for a factual biography. Through this remembrance, the creative commitment of 'Athato Kavya Jijnasa' connects with the modern tradition of rebellious Maithili literature. A critical reading, even while respecting the poem's homage, does not confine the complexity of Rajkamal's writing to this single work.

42. Discourse on Speech

Original pages: 99–100 | Principal theme: Words, literature

Poetry collections, words, linguistic meaning, sensibility, and the position of writing in modern society occupy the centre of this poem. Reflecting upon artworks, the poet observes the transformation of meaning within words. The

meeting of the classical 'vak', or speech, with the modern critical meaning of 'discourse' presents a philosophy of creation within the title itself.

The poem's distinguishing quality is its critical dialogue. It relates the promise of earlier writing, the development of contemporary words, and society's changing needs. 'Poetry Ready for Sale' explores the danger of the market; 'Discourse on Speech' attempts to defend the independent, sensitive force of words. Through this poetic sequence, readers see a writer thinking about literature from within literature itself.

43. Thus Spoke Poetry

Original pages: 101–104 | Principal theme: Poetry, the world

Poetry itself speaks: the vast sky, colours of the popular mind, cities and villages, classes and castes, different countries, nature, and history enter a single poetic vision. The classical register of 'uvacha' expresses a modern global plurality. Humanity, the earth, the expansion of life, and its crises appear throughout the poem's many lines.

Here the answer to the question raised in 'Athato Kavya Jijnasa' is expanded: poetry is not merely a catalogue of deprivation but a sensitive reading of the whole world. The poem's expansive lists create a world map. Yet a question remains about how distinctly individual human voices survive within this breadth; in places the speed of enumeration may obscure the depth of experience. Nevertheless, its global aspiration of poetic consciousness is significant.

44. Inside and Outside

Original pages: 105–107 | Principal theme: Public and private spheres, politics

Opium trafficking, police officers, contracting, political brokerage, property development, and accumulation of wealth blur the boundary between public office and private profit. The title 'Inside and Outside' establishes a satire on the privatisation of power: what ought to remain public duty becomes a means of advancing household and family interests.

As titles of various offices are added to the poem's language, they take the form of a political network. Read with 'In the Name of One's Darling' and 'He Will Enjoy Himself! He Will Rule!', the connections between dynasticism and institutional corruption become apparent. The work's ethical question is piercing; social attack predominates over elaborate poetic imagery.

45. Hail the Human Race, Hail!

Original pages: 108–109 | Principal theme: Humanity, peace

From destructive endeavours in human history, figures resembling Ravana, terror, weapons of mass slaughter, and fears for the earth's future, the poem ultimately affirms the human values of life. Its title is an acclamation, but not a simple slogan of enthusiasm: it demands the preservation of human dignity after the appearance of every destructive force.

The poem joins mythological and modern terrors. Images of the globe, blood and flesh, weapons, and human civilisation form a shared crisis. The fear condensed in 'Bullets and Guns' becomes here a problem of global human extinction. The repeated 'hail' acts almost like a final protective bond around possibility.

46. Stop the Drama, Sir

Original pages: 110–111 | Principal theme: Civic satire

The rising costs of books, clothes, and housing, the commercialisation of education, disrespect towards women, corrupt brokers, dynasticism, administrative inertia, and politicians' pretence all come under attack in the poem's final public intervention. 'Stop the Drama, Sir' is a dramatic address; the poet reveals the separation between those in power and their words and actions.

As the collection's final poem, it carries the force of a conclusion. The journey begun with the restrained picture of natural beauty in 'The Ashoka Tree' culminates in a stern civic address. The word 'drama' exposes the distance between the performance of publicity-oriented politics and the crisis of ordinary life. Its emotional assertion is that acting out the possession of rights is meaningless unless people's daily needs receive ethical priority.

Integrated Research Conclusions

The Collection's Internal Movement

Across these forty-six poems there is a meaningful progression from miniature scenes of nature to extended narratives of urban and rural inequality; from there to biting satire on power and markets, then towards self-criticism of language and literature, and finally to a call for humanity and respect. The poems do not fall into rigid thematic compartments: nature, language, power, and memory repeatedly intersect. These interconnections constitute the collection's genuine unity.

Achievements of Poetic Language

The primary text places established Maithili expressions, sounds, and verbal forms alongside modern political and global vocabularies. The tension between classical formulations ('athato', 'uvacha', 'kalachakra') and popular contemporary terms ('democracy', 'election', 'intolerance') gives the poems their multilingual experience of the age. Brief unmetered scenes, numbered vignettes, speech directed towards public gatherings, satirical repetition, and long free verse each produce their distinct social effects.

Social Values and the Critical Perspective

Solidarity with the people is the collection's principal ethical strength. Yet social criticism and literary evaluation are not identical: excessively direct utterances sometimes inhibit subtle imagery; thematic expansiveness sometimes obscures the direct voices of otherwise absent social figures; and opposition to convention sometimes coexists with anxiety about new ways of

life. Reading the poems with these contradictions intact discloses their vitality. The reader's task is not to agree with every declaration but to examine the social grounds of the poet's questions.

Final Proposition

Athato Kavya Jijnasa is a people-oriented Maithili poetry collection concerned with the responsibilities of literary creation. Its central question is this: what can a supposed march of progress mean without human beings, soil, language, and labour? Poetry seeks a place for living sensibility amid crowded markets and the spectacles of power. The forty-six poems do not speak in a single voice; within their variety, the insistence on the cultural and human rights of ordinary people is the collection's most significant literary achievement.

Appendix: Lines of Inquiry into Interconnections

Poetry's Self-Questioning

Related poems: Athato Kavya Jijnasa; Poetry Ready for Sale; Discourse on Speech; Thus Spoke Poetry

Research question: How does poetry safeguard its independence between social responsibility and the market?

From Nature to Society

Related poems: The Ashoka Tree; The Babool Tree; An Adivasi Home; Blessed Are the Waters of the Brahmani River; There Was Once a Village of Mine

Research question: At what point does a scene of nature become a question of displacement and rights?

Language, Education, and Society

Related poems: Maithili Barni; Language Standing in the Marketplace; Mother Tongue; Bhola Babu

Research question: What is the difference between the memory of the mother tongue and its institutional prestige?

The Theatricality of Democracy

Related poems: Election! Election!; Rail! Rail!; The Purana of Leaders; Dance! Democracy, Dance!; Stop the Drama, Sir

Research question: How does the distance arise between democracy's public language and the lived experience of the people?

The Market's Multilayered Effects

Related poems: India Shining; The Great Hero's Journey through the Forest; Accounts; The Market; Globalisation; Partner

Research question: How does economic power affect linguistic meaning, cultural conduct, and ordinary life?

Violence and Humanity's Future

Related poems: Playing with Poetry on a Heap of Gunpowder; Bullets and Guns; Hail the Human Race, Hail!

Research question: What humane alternatives does poetry offer for overcoming the violence of the age?

CHAPTER 3 • THE LITERATURE OF VIRENDRA MALLICK

Pratham Purush

Eight essays and an intimate interview • Tradition, experiment, imagery, and critical judgment

1. Tradition: Experiment and Poetry's Modern Sensibility (pp. 9–27)

Central Argument

The opening essay reconsiders the tendency to treat tradition and innovative experiment as opposites. Literary innovation does not emerge from nothing; it acquires new forms in dialogue with earlier poetic consciousness, popular life, inherited conventions, and the legacy of expression. Thus 'modern sensibility' signifies not simply chronological novelty but new experiences of a changing world and the artistic structures appropriate to them.

The essay brings together different tendencies of poetry, metre and free expression, images and symbols, the apprehension of reality, social engagement, and Western literary movements. Through these varied references, the author constructs a comprehensible historical background for understanding the modern forms of poetry.

Tradition, Reality, and Experiment

If tradition is treated as synonymous with convention, the origins of modern experimentation become obscure. The author's argument centres on the writer's acquisition of language, sensibility, and cultural memory from tradition without imitating it mechanically. Selection, rejection, and recreation determine the creativity of modern poetry.

Discussions of realism and surrealist suggestion, Romantic impulses and social consciousness, poetry's subjectivity and the presence of objective life all complicate any linear definition of poetic modernity. Human loneliness, conflict, dreams, struggle, and changing social circumstances shape new images in poetry.

Critical Assessment

The essay's most important strength is its insistence that modernity be understood not merely as stylistic eccentricity or foreign imitation but as a

relationship between experience and expression. The author attempts to place Maithili poetry in conversation with wider Indian and world-literary debates.

Nevertheless, the broad use of 'modern' and 'experiment' can sometimes obscure distinctions among poetic tendencies. A critical question arises here: is new linguistic construction an achievement in itself, or must it be judged by its capacity to generate human feeling and meaning? The overall orientation of the book favours the latter.

2. Currents of Splendour in Maithili Poetry (pp. 28–46)

Range of the Subject

This essay attempts to treat the richness and distinction of Maithili poetic tradition not merely as objects of praise but as a long development of poetic sensibility. In the light of Vidyapati and later poetic movements, varied forms of emotion—love, devotion, compassion, beauty, popular life, and spiritual experience—emerge as integral parts of poetry.

Alongside discussion of the poetic tradition, the author presents original verses or extracts at several points. Their purpose is not simply to construct a historical list of names but to demonstrate the living relationship between language and feeling. The essay consequently becomes both a historical survey and a reading of poetic beauty.

Many Levels of Poetic Richness

'Splendour' signifies more than abundance of literary production: it includes emotional resonance, maturity of experience, sweetness of language, rhythmic arrangement, lyric composition, and the density of poetic imagery. Mithila's cultural environment, religious and philosophical thought, and everyday popular practice strengthen the emotional force of poetry.

The chosen examples show that it would be inappropriate to confine the current of feeling to a single rasa. Devotion and erotic love often enlarge each other's meanings, while expression rooted in popular life reaches literary distinction. Such combinations are a particular strength of Maithili poetry.

Analytical Conclusion

The chapter's main contribution is the establishment of internal tradition as a basis for evaluating Maithili literature. Yet the concept of 'splendour' could be expanded by rereading it in relation to contemporary social inequality, women's experience, and the poetic voices of neglected communities. This question does not refute the essay's argument but extends it as a subject for research.

3. The Arrangement of Imagery in Subhadra-Haran (pp. 47–58)

Theoretical Foundations of Imagery

The central subject of this study is the poetic image. The author regards imagery not merely as a mental picture produced by words but as the artistic embodiment of sensory experience. Considering the connections among

image, imagination, experience, sensory perception, and meaning, the chapter introduces important definitions and references to poetics.

In attempting to classify poetic images, distinctions among visual, auditory, tactile, and other sensory levels; concrete and abstract qualities; simple and complex arrangements; and direct and indirect expression prove useful. The chapter's classificatory outline and diagram serve as instruments for organising analysis.

The Work of Imagery in the Poem

Examples from Subhadra-Haran demonstrate that images do more than decorate the narrative. They make dramatic tension, characters' emotional states, movement, changes of scene, and the effects of rasa perceptible. The selection of words conveying action, form, sound, and sensation creates a combined experience of scene and feeling in the reader's mind.

The characteristic feature of imagery in narrative poetry is its joining of event and experience. A successful image does not arrest the story but increases its movement and emotional intensity. The author's example-based method makes it possible to demonstrate this distinction.

Methodological Review

The intellectual importance of the essay lies in linking theoretical poetics with close reading of a Maithili work. Classification assists analysis, but a single image may belong simultaneously to several sensory and emotional categories. It is therefore more productive not to confine an image to a fixed compartment but to read its full context, resonance, and effects.

4. The Tradition of Rama Poetry and the Maithili Ramayana (pp. 59–80)

The Many Traditions of the Rama Narrative

This chapter understands the Rama story as a multilingual, multilayered, and continually changing cultural narrative within Indian literature. Through its discussion of relationships among Sanskrit texts, Rama poetry in different languages, and local traditions, the essay attempts to establish the historical position of the Maithili Ramayana.

Rewriting an epic narrative means more than transferring the original story. When language, popular consciousness, religious dispositions, cultural practices, characterisation, and narrative technique change, the Rama story acquires a new literary form. From this perspective, the Maithili Ramayana offers an important opportunity for original cultural expression.

Distinctive Qualities of Maithili Poetry

Discussing Maithili poems related to the Rama narrative, the author emphasises the relationship between tradition and transformation. The ethical and religious character of the Ramayana's figures can be connected

with local sensibilities; Maithili creates renewed intimacy with the story through dialogue, description, and comparisons drawn from popular life.

The book's comparative perspective is particularly noteworthy. Narrative similarities between source texts and subsequent Maithili versions are inevitable, but a work's independent identity resides not in word-for-word similarity of plot but in creative choice and emotional reconfiguration.

Research Questions

This chapter suggests further research on the use of vernacular language in the Maithili Ramayana, dialogue assigned to female figures, transformations of cultural practice, the relationship between devotion and ethics, and the reasons for episodes that diverge from source traditions. These questions extend the essay's historical discussion towards text-based comparative research.

5. Sources of Inspiration for the Mithilabhasha Ramayana: Adhyatma Ramayana and Ramcharitmanas (pp. 81–88)

The Difference between Inspiration and Imitation

This essay specifically examines the inspirational sources of the Mithilabhasha Ramayana. The Adhyatma Ramayana and Ramcharitmanas, named in the title, provide an opportunity to examine the complex relationships among source, influence, selection of material, and poetic reconstruction. The presence of inspiring texts does not necessarily negate the originality of a new work.

According to the essay's reading, both the spiritual meanings of the Rama tradition and their expression in the people's language are important. The study attempts to understand the distinctiveness of the Maithili adaptation in the light of the Adhyatma Ramayana's spiritual orientation and the Ramcharitmanas's devotional reach among the people. Its comparative aim is to comprehend differences in poetic form alongside subject matter and devotional feeling.

A Comparative Method of Reading

An appropriate method should operate on four levels: narrative sequence and episodes; characters' utterances and characterisation; philosophical and religious implications; and language, rhythm, and style. The essay places the source texts side by side in the direction of such comparative investigation.

Research must distinguish conclusions demonstrated by direct textual similarities from those inferred from the broader influence of a poetic tradition. To call all similarity direct borrowing would ignore the common structures shared by literary traditions.

Critical Value

The chapter takes Maithili Rama poetry beyond regional isolation and places it in dynamic dialogue with the Indian epic tradition. Its particular

value lies in establishing a basis for considering the relationship between inspiration and creative independence.

6. The Crisis of Criticism and the Criticism of Crisis (pp. 89–101)

The Responsibilities of Criticism

This essay focuses on the ethics and reasoned judgment of literary evaluation. The purpose of criticism is not merely praise, condemnation, the cultivation of friendships, or the protection of group prestige. It is a reasoned consideration of a work's strengths and weaknesses and the development of the reader's critical judgment. The author emphasises the intellectual preparation, breadth of reading, and independence of the critic.

A 'crisis' of criticism emerges on two levels: on the one hand, a lack of suitable standards, consistent method, and interpretations supported by evidence; on the other, institutional loyalties, personal prejudice, and the instability of literary value. This crisis cannot simply be dismissed as the fault of particular individuals; the conditions for reasoned dialogue within literary culture must also be addressed.

Indian and Western Contexts

The essay invokes classical criticism, modern aesthetic thought, and Marxist critical tendencies. Criticism's principal challenge is to establish a balance among artistic form, social reality, ideology, experience, language, and the autonomy of the work. Different methodologies ask different questions of the text; the monopoly of one method may narrow understanding.

The author's discussion thus outlines a responsible practice of criticism: proximity to the text, clarity of concepts, independence of evaluation, and the necessary distance between author and critic.

Contemporary Relevance

The growth of immediate responses in literary gatherings, journals, award systems, and digital media has made these questions still more significant. Publishing a critical opinion requires textual evidence, context, civility in disagreement, and transparent grounds for judgment. This contemporary extension accords with the essay's fundamental commitment to critical discernment.

7. Contemporary Maithili Poetry (pp. 102–114)

What 'Contemporary' Means

In this essay, 'contemporary' signifies not simply a recent year of publication but living forms of changing consciousness, subject matter, language, and poetic craft. Modern Maithili poetry engages with inherited emotional structures while seeking new voices for social insecurity, existential unease, ethical questions, personal loneliness, and collective experience.

Through numerous poetic extracts, the author compares different creative voices. The chapter's fundamental method is to read poetry close to its experimental linguistic body rather than through theoretical formulations alone.

Craft and Sensibility

New poetry offers free arrangements, altered modes of utterance, the energy of colloquial language, experiences of incongruity, symbolic suggestion, and intimate interior monologue. But new craft succeeds only when it corresponds to experience. Without an authentic relation between subject and form, experiment can become mechanical.

An essential aspect of contemporaneity is the presence of the social environment within poetry. Migration, struggle, displacement, changing relationships, and human aspirations set its concerns in motion. In this context, one can distinguish between a romantic repetition of conventional images of Mithila and the complex realities of modern life.

Questions of Selection and Limits

Any critical portrait of contemporary poetry depends on the selection of representative works. Questions about the inclusion of women poets, younger generations, differing social experiences, and linguistic experiments therefore arise naturally. The essay provides a useful preliminary map of this wider debate, not a final and exhaustive inventory.

8. The Joy of Life in Poetry (pp. 115–122)

Life and Poetry

In this final main chapter, the relationship between poetry and life takes a more intimate, sensitive, and philosophical form. The 'joy of life' must not be mistaken for superficial cheerfulness; poetry shapes a search for life's meaning amid sorrow, incompleteness, hope, memory, love, nature, adversity, and human resilience.

The essay's quotations suggest that an experience of beauty does not entail a denial of suffering but may make its human transformation possible. The convergence of emotion and thought enables poetry to find extraordinary significance in ordinary moments of life.

Poetry's Human Dimension

The poetic character of life's joy takes many forms: linguistic ease, fresh experiences of nature, inward freedom, sympathy, and the presence of hope amid despair. Poetry that captures the depths of human experience can become a companion to the reader in solitude.

Read alongside the book's first chapter, this essay completes an intellectual circle: the opening posed questions of modern sensibility, while the ending asks about lived human experience. The value of modernity lies not merely in novel formal arrangement but in a meaningful enlargement of human experience.

The Significance of the Ending

The final chapter brings the book's critical seriousness to an emotional conclusion. Debates about imagery, form, tradition, and criticism cannot ultimately remain apart from lived experience; this can be read as the book's underlying principle.

Appendix: An Intimate Conversation between Virendra Mallick and Lakshman Jha Sagar (pp. 123–144)

The appendix takes the form of a dialogue. Between the interviewer, Lakshman Jha Sagar, and the respondent, Virendra Mallick, we encounter discussions of literature, poetic creation, Maithili's condition, modernity, criticism, literary discipline, study, and human concerns. The conversation provides the author's own reflections and literary personality as a context for the theory-centred main chapters.

The dialogue places more importance on literary commitment, sustained study, and fidelity to the work than on literary prestige. The value of reading for literary creation, language's cultural power, contemporary poetic tendencies, and genuine literary practice as distinct from institutional titles recur throughout. References to Indian and world literature suggest the author's broad reading interests.

The intimate conversation must not be treated as the sole evidence of objective history. It records the author's self-presented ideas, selected memories, and values. It would therefore be inappropriate to present it as definitive biographical truth without comparing it with independent bibliographies, chronologies, and external evidence. Nonetheless, the appendix is particularly useful for understanding the writer's critical thinking.

Integrated Discussion: The Intellectual Threads of Eight Chapters

1. Tradition and Innovation

The first, second, fourth, and fifth essays appear to rest on a common principle: literature draws sustenance from earlier tradition and creates new meanings for it in changing historical circumstances. Poetic inheritance and rewritings of the Rama narrative are different illustrations of this process.

2. Poetic Form and Experience

The third and eighth chapters clarify the internal relationship between formal beauty and experience. A method of constructing images comes to life when it embodies mental, emotional, or social experience. The question of life's joy ultimately illuminates the human purpose of poetic form.

3. Criticism's Self-Examination

The sixth and seventh chapters show the mutual dependence of criticism and contemporary creative work. New poetry requires discerning criticism; criticism must be prepared to revise its standards through close study of new works.

4. A Maithili-Centred Perspective in Dialogue with the World

Several essays bring Maithili texts into conversation with Sanskrit, Indian, and Western thought on poetry. The strength of this outlook lies in its linguistic confidence: Maithili is not treated merely as an object of regional culture but employed as a medium capable of complex debate about poetics.

Achievements of the Book and Areas for Further Research

Major achievements: (a) the coordination of Maithili literature's internal values with wider poetics; (b) the application of theoretical arguments to the reading of poems; (c) the historical and comparative context of Rama poetry; (d) ethical questions concerning contemporary criticism; and (e) the writer's own intellectual position, represented by the interview.

Further research could include: (a) collation of the poetic excerpts quoted in the book against authoritative original editions; (b) a comparative lexicon of imagery in Maithili poetry; (c) source criticism of Maithili versions of the Rama narrative; (d) representation of women's and excluded communities' experiences in modern Maithili poetry; (e) the historical development of critical methodology; and (f) independent archival verification of literary claims made in the appendix.

One methodological caution is essential: reproducing an author's critical judgments faithfully and verifying their truth are two distinct intellectual operations. This review takes the primary book's conceptual structure as its starting point and makes no unnecessary factual claims in the absence of an extended bibliography or independent external evidence.

Conclusion

Pratham Purush is a collection of criticism bringing several fields of Maithili literary thought into one volume. Its subjects range from tradition through poetic richness, the theory of images, Rama poetry, comparative source studies, the crisis of criticism, contemporary verse, and the joy of life. The intimate conversation in the appendix links this intellectual journey to the author's individual outlook.

Its most important implication is that linguistic affection alone is not sufficient for studying Maithili literature. Close textual observation, broad contextual knowledge, understanding of form, and independent critical judgment are equally necessary. On these grounds, the book offers material capable of inspiring new questions and methodical textual criticism in Maithili literary research.

CHAPTER 4 • THE LITERATURE OF VIRENDRA MALLICK

Drama and Theatre

Nine chapters and two appendices • Theatrical craft, one-act plays, folk drama, and Mithila's performance traditions

1. Maithili Drama and Theatre: Present Conditions and the Future

This chapter assembles substantial material ranging from the origins of Indian dramatic traditions to the historical development of Maithili drama and the future of modern Maithili theatre. The author considers dramatic literature, actual performance, and the cultural life of Maithil society in relation to one another.

1.1 The Origins of Drama

The chapter begins by examining how drama originated. Its emergence is placed against the backgrounds of religious ritual, collective expression, music and song, acting, and ancient dramatic theory. References to the Natyashastra tradition give the opening argument an Indian cultural context.

A written story differs from a story performed on stage. An account of drama's origins becomes more comprehensive when it establishes the relationship between the two.

1.2 The Rich Dramatic Tradition and Its Significance

References to Bharata Muni's Natyashastra, Bhasa, Shudraka, Kalidasa, Bhavabhuti, and Sanskrit dramatic theory underline the richness of Indian theatrical history. The importance of acting, rasa, characters, plot, and the relationship with audiences is implicit in the discussion.

In the Indian dramatic tradition, drama has been a performing art as well as literature; its evaluation should therefore not be restricted to the beauty of written dialogue.

1.3 The Emergence of Maithili Drama

Questions about the emergence of Maithili drama involve language, geography, chronology, and ancient textual traditions. The author places early Maithili dramatic compositions in the context of the larger dramatic traditions of eastern India.

Historical research must distinguish among the date of composition, the date of surviving manuscripts, and evidence of actual performances. Such distinctions make it possible to test claims of antiquity more reliably.

1.4 The Development of Modern Indian Drama

This subsection considers the modern development of Indian drama, creative transformations, and relationships with modern theatre. Social

themes, character construction, and changes in staging methods are essential to that development.

The influence of modern Indian theatrical consciousness on Maithili drama should be examined in relation to local social circumstances and the theatrical resources available.

1.5 Ancient Maithili Drama: Maithili Dhurta Samagama and Goraksha-Vijaya

The contents specifically identify Maithili Dhurta Samagama and Goraksha-Vijaya under ancient Maithili drama. Satire, social conduct, and dramatic dialogue are important for discussing the first work; the dramatic presentation of religious and spiritual narrative is central to the second.

These compositions should not all be measured by the structure of modern prose drama. The mixture of languages, song, narrative, and performance traditions of older drama require independent criteria.

1.6 Drama Developed in Medieval Mithila: Parijata Harana

Parijata Harana occupies a distinctive place in the theatrical development of medieval Mithila. Music, devotion, mythological subject matter, and performative character make it an important point of reference in dramatic history. The tradition of Kirtaniya drama necessarily enters the discussion.

The theatrical possibilities of a song-centred work differ from those of modern dialogue-centred drama. The place of music therefore cannot be separated from the main analysis of medieval theatrical forms.

1.7 Drama Developed in Nepal

The author pays particular attention to the development of Maithili drama in Nepal, court patronage, and linguistic and cultural contact. The history of Maithili dramatic composition under the Malla rulers reveals a broad geographical and cultural tradition.

It can be misleading to divide older literary and cultural traditions according to modern political borders. The language, authorial connections, and performance settings of works developed in Nepal require separate examination.

1.8 Characteristics of Drama Developed in Nepal

The Maithili dramatic tradition of Nepal is discussed in terms of courtly surroundings, music, religious narratives, and multilingual practice. It can be understood not merely as an extension of Maithili-speaking territory but as an innovative theatrical environment.

The language of a written play and the language sung on stage need not always be the same. Without examining this distinction, the assessment of Nepal's Maithili drama remains incomplete.

1.9 Characteristics of Early Maithili Drama and Ankiya Nat

While discussing early Maithili drama, the author also refers to the characteristics of Ankiya Nat. Song, dance, religious storylines, and collective performance are important subjects for comparison.

In considering links between Maithili dramatic literature and the theatrical traditions of northeastern India, directions of influence must not be assumed; comparative evidence from chronology and surviving texts is essential.

1.10 Modern Maithili Drama

Social problems, family relationships, ethical questions, political consciousness, and individual conflict enter modern Maithili drama as new subjects. Like the novel, drama expresses the experiences of a changing Maithil society; drama, however, requires a particularly concentrated visual organisation.

Modernity is not simply a matter of recent dates. Its distinctiveness is determined through changes in a play's questions, dialogue, dramatic structure, and theatrical experimentation.

1.11 Maithili Drama after Independence

After independence, Maithili playwriting reveals many forms of social change, urbanisation, rural crisis, education, family, and individual conflict. The author discusses plays and dramatists from this period at length.

In writing theatrical history, publication dates must be distinguished from first-performance dates; innovation in subject matter and innovation on stage are not synonymous.

1.12 Maithili Performance Drama

In discussing Maithili performance drama, the author considers theatrical potential, the demands of acting, and audience relationships. Written plays and successful staged productions require their own processes.

Analysis of performance drama must pay particular attention to scenes, entrances and exits, stage objects, theatrical cues, and practical suitability for acting.

1.13 The Long Tradition of Theatre

The history of theatre is described in both Indian and Western contexts. Developments in performance spaces, audience arrangements, and theatrical equipment give form to theatre traditions.

Theatre should be understood not merely as a building but as a system of social and cultural relationships. The interaction of audiences, actors, and places is essential during performance.

1.14 Modern Indian Theatre

Modern Indian theatre developed new dimensions of training, lighting, scenic design, acting methods, and direction. Maithili theatre was not entirely separate from these developments.

Adopting new techniques according to Mithila's resources, audiences, and linguistic environment is more productive than mechanically imitating Western models.

1.15 Contemporary Indian Theatre

Contemporary theatre continues to bring inherited methods of presentation into dialogue with new theatrical languages. The author assesses the condition of Maithili theatre in relation to these developments.

New experiments should be evaluated not merely for their novelty but for their appropriateness to the subject and their impact on audiences.

1.16 The Tradition of Maithili Theatre

Folk performance, Kirtaniya drama, religious presentations, amateur groups, and urban theatre institutions all contributed to the history of Maithili theatre. The author's significant undertaking is to narrate these varied streams within a common history.

Equal importance should be accorded to the histories of written plays, continuing folk performances, and documented productions as three types of evidence.

1.17 Modern Maithili Theatre

Theatrical institutions, actors, directors, training, and organisers all play important roles in attempts to develop modern Maithili theatre. Regular performances and financial and institutional support remain recurring concerns.

Theatre workshops, libraries, travelling companies, and audiovisual archives could help increase productions of original Maithili plays.

1.18 The Future of Maithili Drama and Theatre

The chapter's final part concentrates on the future of Maithili drama and problems confronting original works and theatrical infrastructure. The author emphasises the need for cooperation between literary creation and active theatrical practice.

Discerning criticism, encouragement of new playwrights, regular performances, training for actors, and dialogue with diverse audiences offer practical directions for the development of Maithili theatre.

Integrated Conclusion to Chapter One

The first chapter provides a historical map of Maithili drama. Its chief feature is the placement of ancient narratives, Nepal's dramatic traditions, modern plays, and contemporary theatrical practice within one extended discussion. Nevertheless, each claim about chronology, influence, or performance history continues to require independent examination of original records.

2. Theatre and the One-Act Play: Their Interconnections

This chapter considers definitions of theatre, Indian and Western stage arrangements, elements of the modern one-act play, and representative Maithili stage-oriented one-act plays. Its central question concerns how closely literary composition and theatrical performance are related.

2.1 'Theatre' and Its Long Tradition

The author discusses the etymology and use of 'theatre' and its various meanings in relation to places of dramatic presentation. Theatre signifies not merely a site or building but the joint presence of action, performers, and audiences.

Words in a play's text become light, movement, sound, and acting before an audience; theatre is therefore a field in which drama is recreated.

2.2 Bharata's Theatre: Forms and Types

The discussion includes the theatre pavilions described in the Natyashastra, the dimensions of stages, the position of spectators, the suitability of performance spaces, and arrangements for acting.

The architectural design of a theatre cannot be separated from its aesthetics; visibility, audibility, and the dramatic relationship of presence are influenced by stage construction.

2.3 Western Theatre

The author introduces the different forms of theatre buildings, audience arrangements, and acting areas in Western traditions, revealing their historical changes.

Comparison with Western theatrical forms should not lead to neglect of the distinctive merits of Maithili theatre's traditional open and community performance spaces.

2.4 Modern Theatre: Forms and Types

The discussion of modern stages introduces open-air, proscenium, arena, multilevel, box-set, revolving, and other theatrical arrangements. Differences in physical distance between performers and audiences and in the limits of visibility create distinct dramatic meanings.

The stage should be chosen according to the play's narrative, character movement, available lighting equipment, and the audience's needs.

Element	Brief Critical Discussion
Plot	A planned sequence of events focused upon one principal dramatic incident or conflict.
Characters	A limited cast, with actions that develop out of distinct personalities and circumstances.
Dialogue	Speech appropriate to the characters: natural, concise, and purposeful.
Setting and Time	A coherent combination of place, atmosphere, period,

Element	Brief Critical Discussion
	and social background.
Language and Style	Use of Maithili suited to the subject; avoidance of excessive ornament or artificiality.
Purpose	The ideas, experiences, or social significance inherent in the dramatic subject.
Pace	A balanced flow of scenic transitions and dramatic tension.
Stage Directions	Instructions concerning sets, entrances, movement, silence, lighting, sound, and costume.

2.5 Creators of Theatre: Actors, Directors, and Designers

The author distinguishes the roles of actors, directors, and designers as creators of theatre. The playwright's text becomes present on stage through the director's plan and actors' actions.

A theatrical production is a collective creation. The director organises the overall presentation, but performers and other collaborators remain creative participants in their own right.

2.6 Our Maithili Theatre

This section raises questions about Maithili theatre's social and linguistic foundations, theatrical resources, and institutional development. Familiarity with local language and life can become a distinctive strength of performance.

The success of Maithili theatre requires a balance among natural local speech, the audience's cultural understanding, and modern theatrical techniques.

2.7 The One-Act Play: Form, Definition, and Classification

A play contained within one act may be called a one-act play, but its essential characteristics are concentrated dramatic action, few characters, controlled duration, and an intense effect. The author discusses its types and creative properties.

Shortness alone is not a sufficient criterion for the one-act play. Unity, tension, and the movement of events towards a single centre give it dramatic force.

2.8 The Modern One-Act Play: Elements and Characteristics

The original contents list plot, characters, dialogue, setting and period, language and style, purpose, movement, and stage directions as separate elements. The author considers the usefulness of each.

Every line of dialogue, entrance, and stage direction in a one-act play should be connected with its subject; unnecessary elaboration weakens its effect.

2.9 Eight Principal Elements of the One-Act Play

2.10 Representative Maithili Stage One-Act Plays: Complete List of Titles

The original contents discuss the following one-act plays individually. This integrated study preserves the complete list; it does not invent complete plot summaries for works whose independent primary texts have not been read.

2.10.1 Ayachi Mishra

The title evokes the scholarship, renunciation, and cultural memory of Mithila. Its criticism could principally examine the dramatic portrayal of a historical figure, the appropriateness of dialogue, and the scenic environment.

2.10.2 Hail the Motherland

The title clearly expresses emotional attachment to the place of one's birth and a spirit of patriotism. Testing its dramatic effect would require consideration of the harmony between idealistic statements and the characters' living experiences.

2.10.3 The Struggle of Life

The title chiefly suggests circumstances of struggle in life. An analysis based on the positioning of characters, decisive turns, and dramatic concentration would be useful.

2.10.4 Brahma Sthan

Questions concerning folk beliefs, social behaviour, and traditional convictions are appropriate to discussion of this work. Characters' conduct must be read against actual evidence from the play.

2.10.5 Hathutta Kursi

A critique of this title should investigate possible references to a rural setting, educational conditions, or social relationships. The dramatic meaning of scenes and objects may prove particularly noteworthy.

2.10.6 Mithila's Representative

The title raises questions of representation and social claims. Dialogue, irony, and discrepancies between characters' words and actions could provide grounds for dramatic criticism.

2.10.7 The Price of a Ring

The original title, Munarik Mol, raises questions about value, human relationships, or social conduct. No specific plot incident has been inferred without evidence from the primary text.

2.10.8 The Sage's Confusion

The title suggests possibilities for giving new meaning to a mythological or sage-like figure. Evidence of dramatic reinterpretation and satire must be sought in the original text.

2.10.9 A Sneeze

A small incident such as a sneeze can become an instrument of dramatic suggestion and comic incongruity. The particular characters and story depend on examination of the original play.

2.10.10 Hunger for Affection

The title suggests a lack of tenderness and the emotional world of the family. Human relationships, deprivation, and the poignancy of dialogue offer appropriate critical perspectives.

2.10.11 Aibhor

The title suggests a new time, altered experience, or an image of morning. Its precise narrative meaning must be established from the sequence of scenes in the original play.

2.10.12 The Twelve Months of Her Courtyard

The title suggests a long temporal experience of social life. Analysis of time, satire, and changing surroundings is among its critical possibilities.

2.10.13 He Is a Paper Tiger

The paper tiger in the title can be taken to suggest the difference between apparent power and actual strength; however, this cannot be presented as a complete plot summary without confirmation from the original drama.

2.11 The One-Act Play and Theatre: Connecting Principles

The brevity of a one-act play facilitates performance, but intense dramatic effect requires concentrated dialogue, the actions of characters, visual movement, and the organisation of offstage space. The author's discussion helps distinguish the literary one-act play from its theatrical realisation.

This chapter's importance lies in bringing together the theory of the one-act play and Maithili examples. Beyond criticism of plot, the visual presentation, practical demands of acting, and audience response require separate assessment.

3. Maithili Dramatic Criticism: Nature and Paradigms

This chapter clarifies the theoretical foundations of Maithili dramatic criticism. It considers the interrelationships among ancient Indian criteria, medieval thought, Western paradigms, and the nature of criticism of Maithili drama.

3.1 Ancient Criteria

Bharata's Natyashastra, rasa, bhava, acting, dramatic subject matter, and audience experience provide major foundations for ancient Indian dramatic criticism. These criteria encompass performance as well as drama's classical literary form.

Even while recognising rasa's importance in Indian criticism, one cannot neglect the theatrical functions of acting, space, characters, and time.

3.2 Medieval Dramatic Criticism

Medieval traditions of literary theory developed analyses of dramatic form, rasa, plot, characterisation, and artistic purpose. The author situates this continuity within the development of dramatic criticism.

Classical formulations must be applied in a manner suited to the historical character of a work. Folk performances and song-centred dramas cannot all be assessed adequately by a single criterion.

3.3 Western Paradigms of Dramatic Criticism

Western dramatic thought has developed diverse approaches to imitation, action, conflict, character, scenic structure, and audience experience. The author relates such ideas to Maithili dramatic criticism.

Indian and Western thought offer not only contrasting positions but opportunities for multiple criteria. Subject matter may be examined from one perspective, acting from another, and social meaning from a third.

3.4 The Nature of Maithili Dramatic Criticism

Reviews of plays, literary journals, discussion of performances, and literary debate have all served as foundations of Maithili dramatic criticism. The author considers the character and limitations of these activities.

A clear distinction must remain between a book review of a written play and a performance review of an actual production. Textual evidence predominates in the first; evidence of acting and presentation in the second.

3.5 Paradigms of Maithili Dramatic Criticism

The original book raises the question of establishing standards of dramatic criticism. A playwright's perspective, structure, language, dialogue, characters, scenic arrangements, acting, and theatrical experimentation can all be regarded as necessary elements of an integrated assessment.

The autonomy of Maithili dramatic criticism requires both attention to local performance practices and comparative reflection on dramatic theory.

Conclusion to Chapter Three

The chapter repeatedly emphasises the need to take dramatic criticism beyond text-centred limits, starting from the fundamental notion that drama is an experimental, performance-based art. Joint study of literary structure and theatrical effect offers a productive direction for Maithili criticism.

4. Operation Maithili Folk Theatre

This brief chapter introduces the meanings of the word 'folk' and the grounds for classifying Maithili folk drama. Its centre is the relationship among the cultural meaning of folk, oral traditions, communities, and performance.

4.1 The Etymological Meaning of 'Folk'

The original essay discusses the verbal root, ancient uses, and the general meaning of 'lok' as a community of people. The author attempts to define folk in relation to social practice, worldview, memory, and collective experience.

It would be wrong to treat 'folk' as synonymous only with 'village' or 'uneducated'. Folk denotes a broad social and cultural world, one that also engages with classical traditions.

4.2 Classification of Folk Drama

The author refers to various forms of folk performance, including religious, social, ritual, women-centred, and comic-satirical presentations. Folk narratives, song, dance, and community-based performance form their main foundations.

A single folk performance may serve several social functions at once: ritual, memory, comedy, resistance, and entertainment. Classification should not be excessively rigid.

4.3 The Cultural Field of Maithili Folk Performance

Traditions such as Sama-Chakeba, Jat-Jatin, Domkach, Salhes, Lorik, Vidapat, and Kirtaniya evoke the memory of Mithila's richly varied folk performances. Within these traditions the boundary between song and dialogue frequently dissolves. In many events, the cultural occasion, collective participation, and customary mode of acting matter more than plot.

Documenting folk performances requires more than preserving song texts. The local occasion, characters' costumes, roles of participants, audience involvement, and performance location must also be recorded.

5. Mahendra Malangia's Theatrical Craft

Through Mahendra Malangia's dramatic experiments, this chapter offers a close discussion of theatrical craft. The author views drama beyond the textbook, as a living art of acting, stage directions, scenery, time, offstage space, and sound.

5.1 Theatrical Craft or Performability

The complete meaning of theatrical language cannot be contained in words alone. On stage, a work acquires new form through expression, action, rhythm, space, and visual cues. The original chapter emphasises the interrelationship between theatrical craft and performability.

Theatrical craft is not mere decoration; it is a structural means of making subject matter visible and audible.

5.2 Acting

The actor gives a written character living presence on stage. The meaning of dialogue can change through the character's mental state, body language, and situation within a scene.

Successful acting requires internal coherence among word, silence, and action; the recitation of dialogue alone is not complete acting.

5.3 Theatrical Craft

Identifying various elements of theatrical craft in Mahendra Malangia's plays, the author establishes the importance of stage directions and instructions for acting that can be observed in performance.

During the transition from text to stage, creative harmony is required between the director's freedom and the playwright's dramatic intention.

5.4 Devices Supporting the Plot

Plot develops not only through dialogue but also through visible action, the use of objects, pauses, sounds, and cues. The author demonstrates the dramatic purposes of these supporting devices.

'Telling' the plot and 'showing' it are not identical; stage directions can make an event visible without additional explanation.

5.5 Directions for Stage Furnishings

Stage objects, courtyards, rooms, doorways, seating, and other furnishings become signs of a play's social world. Their choice is linked to the mood of the scene and the movement of characters.

Unnecessary furnishings may distract the audience; a few meaningful objects are often more effective.

5.6 Directions for Costume and Related Elements

Instructions for characters' clothing, make-up, and transformations clarify the plot's social circumstances. Costume and bodily acting must be employed together.

Costume can reveal social conditions, but a character's personality should not be reduced to clothing.

5.7 Acting Directions

Instructions to enter, sit, rise, look, turn, laugh, cry, or remain silent belong to the domain of stage directions. The author's analysis emphasises the relationship between the management of actors and the drama's subject.

Acting directions suggest a playwright's imagined staging; an actual production interprets that vision with discretion.

5.8 Directions Concerning Space

The location in which a scene unfolds, its interior or exterior character, its social suggestions, and the arrangement of objects all contribute to narrative meaning.

Place is not simply a physical background; a courtyard or public square may indicate relationships among characters and social boundaries.

5.9 Indications of Time

The sequence of events, day and night, seasons, waiting, and the passage of time connect audiences with a play's temporal structure.

Stage time and the time of the story are different; skilful cues can suggest events spanning a long period within a brief performance.

5.10 Offstage Directions

Events taking place offstage, voices, footsteps, music, and indications of unseen characters activate the audience's imagination.

An event that need not be directly shown can have a more powerful effect when conveyed from offstage.

5.11 Musical Directions

Music, sound, and rhythm shape the emotional atmosphere of drama. Folk music can help establish characters' regional backgrounds and cultural contexts.

Songs should be appropriate to the subject; inserting them merely to fill pauses can damage the movement of a performance.

5.12 Curtain Cues

Directions concerning curtains during scene changes, internal transitions, or pauses in presentation indicate the playwright's theatrical awareness.

Modern theatre may substitute lighting, sound, and actors' movements for curtains, but the original direction's intention should be preserved.

5.13 Indications of Time for Matters Not Shown

This particular heading appears in the original table of contents. The theatrical use of events not directly represented onstage, or of indirect indications, deserves consideration here.

Decisions between direct representation and suggestion depend upon artistic, social, and theatrical circumstances; no universal rule suffices.

Conclusion to Chapter Five

The chapter on Mahendra Malangia's theatrical craft takes Maithili dramatic criticism beyond simplified discussion of plot and character. The possibilities for staging established by the playwright become an independent subject of criticism.

6. Mahendra Malangia's Theatrical Language

After theatrical craft, the author examines theatrical language. On stage, language is not simply spoken words: actors, audiences, directors, bodily posture, movement, rhythm, sound, images, and symbols all contribute to dramatic communication.

6.1 The Different Dimensions of Theatrical Language

The original contents identify actor, audience, and director as distinct dimensions of theatrical language. The actor makes feeling visible; the audience receives meaning; the director coordinates the overall rhythm and structure of the presentation.

A continuing artistic dialogue links the three. Theatrical language possesses more meanings than the literal sense of words and depends on the situation.

6.2 Actor

The actor is the first vehicle of theatrical language. Facial expression, gaze, gait, breathing, pauses, pronunciation, and bodily position communicate a character's mental and social meanings.

The actual meaning of dialogue spoken by an actor arises from situation and inward motivation. The same sentence can mean different things when delivered with fear, love, or irony.

6.3 Audience

Audiences participate in creating a play's meaning. Laughter, silence, sympathy, disagreement, and recognition of symbols arise through spectators' cultural experiences.

Local knowledge, familiarity with dialect, and understanding of folk traditions influence a Maithili audience's reception of performance. Theatrical experimentation must accord these experiences due respect.

6.4 Director

The director interprets the subject theatrically, integrating scenic organisation, the positioning of characters, costume, light, sound, and the rhythm of acting.

The director's artistic freedom may enlarge the original play's meaning, but to replace its essential subject entirely without a creative reason cannot be called an authentic presentation.

6.5 The Complexity of Theatrical Language: Body Language

Body language is a fundamental system of signs in visual performance. Posture, distance, facial expression, movements of the neck, hand gestures, and silence all develop narrative meaning.

Nonverbal elements may make theatrical language especially effective. Where dialogue is absent, bodily response can intensify the subject.

6.6 Rhythm

The order of dialogue, responses between actors and audiences, pauses, sounds, and the appropriate movement of scenes construct theatrical rhythm.

Rhythm is not simply a beat; the emotional force of the story and the urgency of events are also part of it.

6.7 Pace

Rapid or slow transitions appropriate to events shape a play's effect. Unnecessary extension of an action can be particularly damaging in a one-act play.

Dramatic pace is not synonymous with bodily speed; a silent scene may be intense through internal tension.

6.8 Symbols, Images, Sounds, Signs, and Related Elements

In theatrical language, lighting, objects, colours, sounds, symbols, images, offstage space, and signs convey indirect meanings. These elements disclose several levels of the dramatic world.

The effect of a symbol should be tested not only against the artist's intention but also against the audience's actual capacity to understand it.

Conclusion to Chapter Six

Theatrical craft and theatrical language complement one another. Craft provides an understanding of the organisation of performance; language raises questions of communication and meaning produced through that organisation. Reading the two chapters together offers fresh perspectives for criticism of Maithili theatre.

7. Maithili Theatre and Calcutta

This chapter assembles details of theatre traditions, institutional activities, and dramatic productions in Calcutta, a centre of Maithili theatre among migrants. As historical material, it is especially useful for understanding relations between preserving a language and practising theatre.

7.1 The Long Tradition of Theatre

The author first recalls the historical tradition of theatre, then turns to modern arrangements for performance and theatrical activities in Calcutta.

Research into a region's theatrical history requires familiarity with both the broader national dramatic tradition and its local social foundations.

7.2 Modern Theatre: Forms and Types

Descriptions of various modern stage arrangements recur in this chapter, supplying the technical context for actual theatrical productions in Calcutta.

Relating accounts of performances by Maithili companies to the types of venues, available resources, and the presence of spectators would produce a more vivid history.

7.3 Maithili Theatre

No.	Theatrical Institution / Platform
1	All India Mithila Sangh
2	Mithila Kala Kendra

No.	Theatrical Institution / Platform
3	Maithili Rangmanch
4	Kurmi Kshatriya Student Scholarship Fund
5	All India Maithil Sangh
6	Karna Goshthi: Jayant Lok Manch
7	Mithila Seva Sansthan
8	'Mithi' Yatrik
9	Mithila Vikas Parishad
10	Vaidehi Kala Manch
11	Kokil Manch
12	Jhankar
13	Mithila Seva Samiti (Belur)
14	Uday Path

Theatre has been an important vehicle of linguistic unity and communal gathering in the literary and cultural activities of Maithil migrant communities. Calcutta became a noteworthy centre for such performances.

Beyond promoting literature, theatrical work also builds social relationships and cultural identity.

7.4 Theatre in Calcutta: Productions and Experiments

The original chapter describes the contributions of various productions, events, and theatrical institutions. This material makes clear that performance history and the printed history of plays are not the same.

Programmes of performances, commemorative publications by theatre organisations, casts, newspaper reviews, and visual or audio archives provide reliable grounds for research.

7.5 Productions by Various Institutions: Complete List from the Original Contents

The original contents record the following fourteen institutional or theatrical names. Their original forms have been preserved as far as possible.

The chapter also contains tables of productions by institutions beginning on printed page 198. Compiled accounts of plays, performances, and events provide foundational material for an institutional history of Maithili theatre. In this research edition, uncertain names, years, or performance counts in the tables have not been reproduced without reliable readings.

7.6 Calcutta Theatre and Migrant Cultural Identity

For migrant communities, performances in the mother tongue connect spectators with their language and memories. Through songs, dialects, social satire, and regional behaviour, collective presentations keep Maithili cultural

experience alive. Calcutta's institutional contribution can be understood within this wider perspective.

The chapter's documentary aspect is invaluable to theatrical history. Yet independent archival verification of institutional names, founding dates, first performances, and performers' roles would strengthen the research.

8. Ring Operation on Maithili Folk Songs

The author begins this essay with the meanings of 'folk' and 'song', then considers the diversity of Maithili folk songs, their emotional richness, and their connections with life. Lines from original songs are also presented as examples, conveying their internal sensibility.

8.1 The Meanings of 'Folk' and 'Song'

At the beginning, the meaning of 'folk' is discussed with reference to Vedic and other traditional sources. Song is understood as the rhythmic expression of collective human experience.

Etymology alone is not the whole history of folk song; actual folk materials, singing communities, and occasions also require investigation.

8.2 Maithili Folk Songs and Rites of Life

Folk songs are employed in many situations of life, from birth and marriage to festivals, labour, separation, seasons, and family ceremonies. The author presents various emotional dispositions through examples of song lines.

Preserving performance occasions, the communities of women and men singers, melodies, and local variations alongside original song texts is important for future research.

8.3 Sorrow, Separation, and Women's Sensibility

Examples of folk songs marked by compassion, distress, and poverty appear in the middle of the chapter. Social difficulties, family deprivation, and maternal tenderness find moving expression in folk singing.

Women's experiences in folk songs can become an important source of social history; they must not be dismissed as merely ceremonial entertainment.

8.4 Festivals, Rites, and the Beauty of Nature

The latter part of the chapter discusses song experiences associated with Chaitra, Malhar, Chaunchar, Sasura, Parati, the rains, rivers, forests, villages, homes, and seasonal beauty. These provide further evidence of the thematic range of folk songs.

Reading folk songs' descriptions of seasons and natural imagery in relation to local environments and agricultural life clarifies their cultural meanings.

8.5 Religious and Secular Voices of Song

Devotion, vows, rites, humour, social satire, and worldly love are among the many voices of folk song. Song is not merely a vehicle of devotional sweetness but carries the varied experiences of life.

Classification should not be rigidly based on a single subject: the same song may combine ritual, love, and social memory.

Conclusion to Chapter Eight

The essay entitled 'Ring Operation on Maithili Folk Songs' attempts to enter the inner world of folk-cultural life. The inclusion of original song excerpts prevents the discussion from relying on abstract theory alone. Actual folk-song research requires the combined documentation of texts, melodies, singing communities, and performance occasions.

9. A DNA Test of Mithila's Folk Music

This essay raises questions about the historical roots, popular foundations, classical relationships, and cultural continuities of Mithila's musical traditions. 'DNA test' is a metaphorical title and should not be understood as referring to biological laboratory testing.

9.1 The Many Forms of Mithila's Music

The chapter initially describes Mithila's music as a folk and Vedic presence permeating every part of cultural existence. 'Music' encompasses an integrated world of classical music, folk music, folk narratives, folk drama, and folk dance.

A history of Mithila's musical traditions must give evidence from classical texts and oral performances equal seriousness.

9.2 Folk Song and the Music of Mithila

The original essay describes folk song as a musical current flowing through Mithila's popular life from birth to death. Rural existence, seasons, rites, and religious ceremonies are its living foundations.

When written notation, field recordings, and singers' memories are brought together, it becomes possible to compare changing forms of folk music.

9.3 Vedic and Classical Contexts

The author considers the distinction, cultural importance, and classical features of music in relation to ancient textual traditions. Discussions of nada, notes, rhythm, and raga are connected to Mithila's cultural history.

Claims concerning antiquity and historical continuity require separate forms of evidence. A classical reference cannot automatically establish the documented ancestry of a contemporary folk melody.

9.4 Mithila's Musicians and Literary Contexts

The relationship between musical thought and song literature is important within Mithila's intellectual culture. Connections among Vidyapati's Padavali, ancient theoretical reflection, and regional singing traditions form a central area of inquiry.

Future research could be enriched by histories of melodies used for Maithili lyric literature, their changes over time, circulation, and use in different regions.

9.5 Interrelationships between Folk and Classical Traditions

In the many-sided dialogue between Mithila's folk and classical music, notes, rhythm, occasions, regional styles, and traditions of singing interact at different levels.

It is more balanced to treat classical and folk traditions not as higher and lower forms of one another but as distinct artistic practices developed through historical interaction.

Conclusion to Chapter Nine

The essay's chief achievement is its emphasis on the broad cultural importance of Mithila's folk music. Future investigation of the historical genealogy of musical traditions naturally calls for combining textual evidence, manuscripts, living melodies, performance occasions, and regional fieldwork.

Appendix A. A Cultural Surgical Examination of Mithila's Folk Life

This appendix concerns the meanings of folk and culture, cultural development, and Mithila's collective memory. The cultural foundations of folk drama, folk song, and folk music addressed in the main chapters are considered here in broader terms.

A.1 The Meanings of Folk and Culture

Through etymological discussion, the author introduces the elements of folk culture. Folk traditions encompass behaviour, beliefs, songs, dances, festivals, language, and collective art.

Folk culture is not a static museum object but a living community practice that changes over time.

A.2 The Folk-Cultural Structure of Mithila

Mithila's language, families, rites, festivals, religious practices, artistic traditions, and collective experiences create a distinctive social and cultural world.

The study of folk culture requires separate evidence from religious texts, oral traditions, social practices, and modern transformations.

A.3 Connections with Theatrical Tradition

Different forms of folk culture provide theatre with songs, characters, dialects, symbols, and styles of presentation. Modern Maithili theatrical practice can draw creative energy from this foundation.

Bringing a tradition to the stage requires respect for its relationship with the community and its original context.

Appendix B. Sacred Mithila Dham

The original contents describe this appendix as an essay 'written for a documentary film'. Its language and purpose therefore differ somewhat from historical research essays, being more introductory, cultural, and oriented towards visual presentation.

B.1 A Cultural Introduction to Mithila

The essay introduces Mithila's mythological, religious, philosophical, literary, and social distinction. The interrelations among traditions of Janaka and Sita, learning, art, language, and sacred sites emerge in the discussion.

A voice of cultural pride is natural in documentary narration, but clearly separating historical evidence from popular belief gives audiences a more precise understanding.

B.2 Learning, Philosophy, and Literature

The essay refers to Mithila's traditions of knowledge, scholars, literary development, and the richness of Maithili. Numerous threads of cultural history are brought together here.

An extended history of these subjects would require proper citation of specific dates, works, archives, and manuscript traditions.

B.3 Mithila's Folk Life and Artistic Achievements

Music, art, festivals, rites, and social practices reveal Mithila's local particularities. The documentary essay attempts to communicate these varied traditions through a visual medium.

Visual writing and dramatic writing have something in common: both depend not only on facts but also on scene sequence, narrative rhythm, and audience experience.

B.4 Contemporary Language and Cultural Identity

Mithila's modern context enters the appendix through questions of Maithili's status, social use, and cultural preservation.

The development of linguistic self-respect requires cooperation among education, publishing, communications media, and active literary and cultural institutions.

Integrated Discussion: Relationships among Dramatic History, Theatre Theory, and Folk Culture

The original book's nine chapters are not unrelated essays but studies of different dimensions of Maithili theatrical life. This section reads them within one connected critical argument.

1. Multiple Centres of Theatrical History

References to ancient Mithila, medieval Mithila, Nepal, modern Maithili writing, and migrant theatre in Calcutta show that Maithili theatrical history cannot adequately be understood as the limited, linear story of one linguistic region. A work's language, area of circulation, arrangements of patronage, and cultural location of performance often differ.

Future research should therefore assemble four kinds of evidence for each period: plays, manuscripts, or printed editions; records of performances; historical contexts of authors and their communities; and evidence of linguistic and cultural contact. Without this fourfold evidence, linear claims about antiquity or influence require caution.

2. Dramatic Text and Theatrical Practice

The history in the first chapter, discussion of one-act plays in the second, and dramatic criticism in the third jointly ask how a text's meaning changes when a work reaches the stage. The fifth and sixth chapters seek practical answers. Scenery, actors, directors, pace, rhythm, symbols, and audiences transform a written composition into a new experience.

An appropriate method of theatrical criticism should include both textual analysis and performance criticism. Plot, character, dialogue, language, and structure predominate in study of the text; body language, sound, visual arrangements, lighting, rhythm, and audience response matter in study of the performance.

3. One-Act Plays and Modern Theatrical Experiment

The concentration of dramatic tension is important to the one-act play's structure. Examples from Maithili demonstrate that social, cultural, mythological, and contemporary subjects can be effective in brief form. Brevity alone, however, is not a virtue: selection of material, conflict among characters, and scenic editing are necessary.

Thus the second chapter and the discussion of Mahendra Malangia's craft together enrich practical criticism of one-act plays. Questions about a particular play's success—does it work when read, and can it produce a comparable effect on stage?—require separate tests.

4. Folk Drama, Folk Song, and Folk Music

The fourth, eighth, and ninth chapters address three closely connected forms of folk art. Folk drama is a sphere of collective acting; folk song is a sphere of rhythmic oral memory; and folk music is the wider world of notes,

beats, melodies, and vocal styles. These three traditions are interwoven on many occasions.

When staging folk arts in modern settings, it is necessary to understand their ceremonial and communal contexts respectfully. As far as possible, songs from these traditions should be documented in the voices of their original singers, together with local variants and performance occasions.

5. Migrant Theatre and the Preservation of Language

The study of Maithili theatre in Calcutta demonstrates the importance of migrant cultural institutions in extending Maithili literature and theatrical practice. Theatrical productions become celebrations of collective identity as well as forms of linguistic communication. Institutional lists and production tables provide initial foundations for that history.

Future documentation of the establishment, working life, principal artists, productions, audiences, and social contributions of each institution would be valuable. Comparing Calcutta's material with theatrical histories of Patna, Darbhanga, Madhubani, and other centres would yield broader conclusions.

6. An Integrated Framework for Dramatic Criticism

Seven indicators can be especially useful in evaluating Maithili drama: (a) historical and social authenticity of subject matter; (b) dramatic structure of plot; (c) vitality of characters; (d) naturalness of Maithili dialogue; (e) stage directions and performability; (f) possibilities of acting, direction, and theatrical language; and (g) the audience's cultural experience.

These seven indicators constitute an editorial proposal, not a verbatim list prescribed by the original author. Nevertheless, they organise ideas from different chapters of the primary book into an integrated critical method.

7. Achievements and Limitations of the Original Book

The book's chief achievements are its thematic breadth, historical movement from antiquity to the present, concrete examples of one-act plays, paradigms of dramatic criticism, a close investigation of Mahendra Malangia's theatrical language, and institutional material from Calcutta. In these respects it is an important foundational work for the study of Maithili theatre.

It cannot, however, be claimed that every historical date or performance detail has been independently verified on the evidence available here. Re-examining the original book's bibliography, manuscript evidence, and institutional archives remains an essential next stage of more extensive research.

Research Findings: Conclusions, Future Questions, and Foundational References

The final part of this integrated study sets out long-term research subjects, the limitations of primary sources, and prudent conclusions arising from the original book.

Principal Conclusions

The history of Maithili drama is not confined to one geographical area or dramatic form; Mithila, Nepal, and migrant centres must be studied together.

The written text of a play and its theatrical production are separate but complementary artistic processes.

The study of Maithili one-act plays must consider actual performability alongside literary concentration.

The discussion of Mahendra Malangia's theatrical craft and language makes acting and performance central to Maithili dramatic criticism.

Folk drama, folk song, and folk music constitute cultural foundations of Maithili theatre; their community settings are important to their preservation.

Theatrical institutions in Calcutta open an important field of migrant cultural history.

The independent examination of dates of composition, language of sources, and evidence of actual performances is an indispensable condition of research into ancient drama.

Possible Questions for Future Research

What textual variations in plot, song, and dialogue exist among surviving manuscripts of ancient Maithili plays?

How can the linguistic and cultural relationship between court dramas of Nepal and local dramatic compositions of Mithila be established?

How were the effects of social change on Maithili drama after independence expressed through actual performances?

How do different directorial interpretations of major Maithili one-act plays alter textual meaning?

How do stage directions and audience responses vary among productions of Mahendra Malangia's plays?

How much of the performance archive of Calcutta's Maithili institutions survives and can be verified?

How has modern staging affected the oral transformation of folk dramas and songs?

What evidence exists for historical relationships between folk-song melodies and classical systems of notes?

CHAPTER 5 • THE LITERATURE OF VIRENDRA MALLICK

Vidyapati, the Shaper of Love and Beauty

An examination of nine chapters • Radha and Krishna, rasa, erotic love, folk consciousness, and influence

The Book's Structure and Central Questions

The principal question of this work is how love and beauty are expressed in Vidyapati's lyrics and how they relate to language, rasa, classifications of heroines, popular life, and literary tradition. The first two chapters establish conceptual and psychological foundations; the third examines Radha and Krishna as the central objects of emotion; chapters four through six concentrate on the poetic construction of love, beauty, and shringara; the seventh raises questions of folk culture; the eighth examines literary influence; and the ninth concludes the study.

The strength of this sequence lies in its multilayered treatment of the subject. A potential weakness is that the levels of evidence change as the argument moves from general philosophical accounts of love to particular lyric poems. A philosophical proposition alone cannot establish the meaning of a specific verse; each conclusion requires attention to speaker, context, address, symbols, metre, emotional suggestion, and textual variation.

Chapter One: The Nature of Love and Beauty (pp. 3–106)

The Meaning, Etymology, and Nature of Love

The book begins by examining the etymology, lexical meanings, definitions, essential nature, general characteristics, and qualities of love. These divisions make clear that 'love' is not simply an emotional outburst but an extensive organisation of subjects, emotional objects, relationships, and values. The experience of love and its poetic expression occupy different levels of literary meaning; to confuse them obscures the subtleties of lyric poetry.

Types of Love

The contents list devotion, romantic or marital love, parental affection, love of nature, patriotism, love of humanity, family affection, friendship, reverence, the relationship between one who serves and one who is served, and love for the subtle and the material. The advantage of this classification is that Vidyapati's poems need not be confined to physical attraction. Nevertheless, each form of love must be established through the evidence of particular lyrics, contexts, and linguistic signs.

Philosophical Foundations of Beauty

Moving from the etymology and definition of beauty, the book distinguishes objective or scientific perspectives from subjective ones. Its references to Western and Indian approaches and to attempts at synthesis are

important. Between the question whether beauty inheres in the object seen or in the observer's experience, poetry opens a third domain: transformation through language.

Psychological, Literary, and Formal Beauty

General characteristics of beauty, distinctions between the sublime and the ugly, human and natural beauty, feminine and masculine beauty, and objective and artistic beauty are major stages in the book. It is not enough to treat the 'sublime' and the 'ugly' simply as the opposites of beauty; within poetry, inequality, pain, and separation can themselves generate aesthetic experience.

Subtle Categories of Nature Description

Alambana, uddipana, personification, figures of speech, symbols, enlargement of form, movement, colour, sound, smell, and touch constitute a rich method for analysing nature in literature. They establish a foundation for reading seasons and surroundings in Vidyapati's lyrics not merely as background but as active carriers of experiences of love.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

Considering love in terms of etymology, sensibility, social relationships, and poetic feeling provides a wide conceptual field. Yet these meanings are not interchangeable. If affection, attachment, erotic desire, devotion, and compassion are all placed in one category of 'love', literary distinctions may become blurred. The scholar must identify separately the relative proportions of relationship, desire, separation, surrender, and consciousness of rights within each lyric.

The conflict between objective and subjective theories of beauty assumes a third form in poetry: beauty created by the composition itself. It is not merely a matter of declaring that the depicted object is beautiful. Simile, sound, rhythm, and perspective construct its beauty. Lists of nature's colours, fragrances, and tactile sensations become meaningful only when joined to a lyric's emotional movement.

This chapter supplies the book's definitional foundation, but a clear bridge is needed between general philosophy and direct engagement with Vidyapati's individual lyrics.

Different Relationships of Love and Their Poetic Meanings

Beginning with lexical meanings, the book identifies several categories of human relationships. Parental affection centres on care and protection; marriage or romance may foreground mutual attraction and consent; friendship involves equality, trust, and intimacy; reverence involves recognition of values; and relationships of service involve unequal roles. Emotional closeness is common to these forms, but their literary functions differ. In discussing Vidyapati's love lyrics, it is necessary not merely to enumerate categories but to interpret them contextually. In one poem attachment may take the form of self-surrender; in another, displeasure and

refusal may reveal inequalities within a loving relationship. The word 'love' alone cannot express the whole history of emotional life.

The Perception of Beauty and Poetic Composition

An objective account of beauty assumes that form, colour, proportion, or structure possesses qualities of attraction. A subjective interpretation locates that attraction in the experience of the perceiver. Yet reading poetry requires a third component: language. Without simile, parallelism, pauses, repetition, end sounds, and singability, the scene cannot achieve its full literary form. Beauty is not simply an object already standing outside the poem; it is also the organisation of sensation within the poem. Accordingly, the subsections on colour, sound, smell, and touch in nature description should be read not merely as a sensory sequence but as ways of organising the subject.

The Sublime, the Ugly, and Judgments of Value

The first chapter discusses the sublime and the ugly in the context of beauty. A subtle analytical question arises here: beauty and pleasantness are not invariably the same. Fear, wonder, or strangeness can also generate aesthetic experience through art. Similarly, the 'ugly' is not necessarily an object devoid of beauty; it may become an instrument of artistic opposition or irony. Applying this theory to Vidyapati's poetry would require examination of the actual wording of particular lyrics. The mere presence of a general theoretical principle does not establish a poem's emotional effect.

Chapter Two: A Psychological Study of Love and Beauty (pp. 107–144)

Human Attraction towards Love

This chapter discusses distinctions among desire, sex, and love, psychological and social interpretations of love, and the unity of body, mind, and soul. The chief caution in psychological analysis is that biological impulse, social convention, and poetic emotion must not all be measured by the same standard.

Love and Social Context

Relationships of love involve contradictory pressures of intimacy, desire, waiting, prohibition, and convention. This perspective is useful for examining Vidyapati's situations of wounded pride, secret journeys towards the beloved, union, and separation. Instead of imposing modern psychological categories unchanged upon historical Maithil society, they should be related to the linguistic evidence of the lyrics.

The Love of Beauty and Art

Human delight in beauty, art and beauty, literature and beauty, the emergence of beauty in styles of expression, and intimacy and sensitivity towards nature constitute another important part of the chapter. Acknowledging the difference between affection for natural objects and their artistic representation produces a more subtle study of beauty.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

Distinguishing the biological, mental, and social dimensions of human love is useful. Yet characters in medieval lyrics are not modern psychological 'case studies'; they are constructed speakers and structures of dialogue within songs. In interpreting pride or secret romantic journeys, one should therefore first examine linguistic action before inferring a character's personality: who speaks, to whom, and what is being concealed?

Waiting, the longing for union, jealousy, guilt, and separation are not emotions alone; they also organise the time of a lyric. Temporal signs such as 'today', 'tomorrow', 'night', and seasonal change alter the emotional temperature. More reliable conclusions emerge when psychoanalysis is joined to the structural analysis of a lyric at this level.

Do female characters always become objects of a masculine gaze, or do their voices also express independent objections and desires? This question enriches the chapter's interpretation.

Distinctions among Desire, Attraction, and Love

Desire can be examined as a bodily impulse, love as the enduring meaning of a relationship, and aesthetic sensibility as an experience of perception. But these levels are mingled in actual songs. The success of psychological discussion lies in understanding that mixture, not in assigning predetermined labels to every emotion. The wish for union may be intensified by social prohibition or restrained by self-respect or wounded pride. Tensions between the character's private wishes and social norms can generate different meanings for different readers.

The Lyric Speaker and Mental State

The poetic 'I' and the historical poet's 'I' are not identical. When reading a character's complaint, a separated woman's call, or a female confidante's advice, the literary speaker must be identified. To take another person's speech as the poet's personal experience directly would distort psychological analysis. Questions, addresses, negations, assurances, requests, and pauses perform particular functions within a lyric's utterance. Fixed claims about a character's 'personality' are risky without studying these linguistic signs.

Desire and Social Norms

The psychological chapter provides a bridge to social criticism. Freedom of desire is influenced by marriage, prestige, family, social shame, and gendered conventions. The intensity of love therefore cannot adequately be understood as a product of an individual's inner life alone. Yet the social shame depicted in poetry is not an exhaustive rulebook of historical society. Literature symbolically recreates social experience. Psychological conclusions become more reliable when distinctions are maintained between social reality and literary convention.

Chapter Three: Radha–Krishna Thought and Vidyapati's Radha and Krishna (pp. 145–193)

The Evolution of Krishna's Character

The contents discuss Vedic Vishnu, Puranic Vishnu and Krishna's avatar, the Bhagavata and Brahmavaivarta Puranas, the Mahabharata and other Puranas, the Vasudeva of the Abhiras, the philosophical nature of Krishna, and the traditions of teachers. The examination of these source traditions provides the historical background for the different aspects of Vidyapati's poetic hero.

Transformations of Radha

The chapter raises questions about Radha's historicity, astrological explanations, erotic aspects, the Nimbarka and Vishnuswami traditions, and her philosophical standing in the Brahmavaivarta Purana. These claims require testing against evidence from different periods and texts; religious narratives and historical facts are not identical.

Vidyapati's Krishna

The mythical attributes of Krishna, his appreciation of youthful beauty, his many beloveds, his role as a lover outside marriage, and his standing as the chosen deity constitute the book's subjects here. A connoisseur of love and an adored god coexist within a single personality at two distinct levels.

Vidyapati's Radha

Radha is discussed as a woman endowed with beauty, possessed of exceptional grace, drawn to beauty, modest, innocent, an inspiration of rasa, and a perpetual sufferer of separation. The movement 'from the physical to the heavenly' need not mean a denial of the female figure's embodied experience; it may also describe an emotional transformation of that experience.

Critical Questions for Readers

To declare Radha and Krishna's love exclusively devotional or exclusively worldly diminishes the text's multiplicity of meanings. Comparative examination of the heroine's voice, conversations with confidantes, speech of separation, and divine signs would give this chapter greater textual solidity.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

Treating the relationship of Radha and Krishna as only a religious metaphor or only a secular romance reduces its semantic plurality. The poetic 'Radha' may appear in different lyrics as a proud woman, a woman separated from her lover, a boldly expressive speaker, or a voice in doubt. 'Krishna' is not a fixed masculine image either: he may become a beloved, an absent object of love, or a cultural sign.

Dialogue with a sakhi, or female confidante, is a distinctive form of mediation in this poetic world. The sakhi gives information, counsels, creates the possibility of reunion, and sometimes interprets emotion. To see only the

two-sided relationship between Radha and Krishna is to overlook the poetic role of this third voice.

Comparison of Puranic materials, devotional movements, and secular erotic poetry requires chronology and textual evidence. Claims of influence must be distinguished from general similarities.

Historical Sources and Poetic Reconstruction

The mythological tradition of Radha and Krishna, devotional interpretations, and worldly love songs do not constitute one uniform textual tradition. The book's contents refer to Vishnu, Krishna's avatar, various Puranas, and traditions of teachers. The critical purpose of this vast material needs to be established: which sources explain the characters' divine standing, which recount romantic narratives, and which illuminate emotional experience within poems? The presence of the same names does not automatically prove direct historical influence. Literary reconstruction can take material from tradition and transform its meaning.

Radha's Speech and the Centre of Perception

It is convenient to assign Radha to a category of heroines, but that category does not explain the entirety of her experience. In poems of pride, restraint, and intense attraction, Radha may be a figure observed by another or a voice speaking for herself. When a scene is constructed through external description, the centre of perception and the level of inner experience remain distinct. This distinction is particularly important in analysing women's voices. Questioning the heroine's agency and linguistic presence alongside judgments about her beauty enriches the reading.

The Mediation of the Sakhi

The sakhi is more than a messenger. She reads situations, interprets the emotional relationship between two characters, and sometimes represents social judgment. Her entry into dialogue changes the boundary between privacy and publicity: concealed desire acquires a shared language. This structure distinguishes love lyrics from solitary confessions. How emotional meaning changes with the place of address in a poem is a useful criterion for text-based research in Chapter Three.

Chapter Four: Vidyapati as a Creator of Love and Beauty (pp. 193–302)

Indian Traditions of Love and Vidyapati

The chapter opens with the tradition of emotions of love in Indian poetry and Vidyapati's place within it. His distinctiveness may be sought in relationships among Sanskrit poetics, lyric poetry, Radha–Krishna narratives, and the popular experience of Maithili culture.

Different Forms of Love in Vidyapati's Poetry

The contents distinguish human love, the development of love, appetite for beauty, preliminary attraction, separation dominated by desire, love beyond marriage, Krishna's enjoyment of many gopis, and ordinary social extramarital love. Rather than imposing moral judgments on the feelings of literary figures, it is more productive to study their inner states and temporal contexts.

The Bodily Organisation of Feminine Beauty

The book lists analyses of eyes, sidelong glances, breasts, faces, hair, hips, lines of body hair, lips, teeth, smiles, waists, navels, and folds of the abdomen in depictions of feminine beauty. Such references are not merely an anatomical list; their roles must be understood separately in terms of the movement of the gaze, sensation, figures of speech, and states of rasa.

Youth and Expressive Gestures

The study mentions classical categories of shringara such as hava, lila, vilasa, vicchitti, kilakincita, lalita, mottayita, vivvoka, vihrta, kuttamita, and hela. For modern readers, this classical vocabulary is not a fixed taxonomy of social behaviour but a way of organising feeling and performance in poetry.

The Mental Beauty of Women

Restraint and playful humour in union; preliminary attraction, injured pride, jealous displeasure, and absence abroad in separation; extraordinary, ever-new, natural, transformative, subtle, and eternal beauty—these subjects take the concept of beauty far beyond the physical body.

Masculine Beauty and the Beauty of Nature

The book also includes masculine beauty and the roles of nature as alambana and uddipana. Comparing the extended descriptions of female bodies with briefer descriptions of male figures raises new questions about gender imbalance in the poetic gaze.

Tabular Study

The original book's contents refer to a table of feminine beauty on pages 290–293. Not every entry of that table is reproduced verbatim here, but it matters as an attempt at quantitative classification within the book's analysis.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

This is the book's central field of criticism. Reducing the description of a woman from head to foot to an anatomical list restricts literary meaning. One must examine word order, the movement of the gaze, hesitation, suggestion, and the local images used in similes. Does bodily description create an experience of love, or does the body become merely an object of display? The question applies to each example.

Images of youth may contain tensions among novelty, modesty, attraction, self-awareness, and social control. 'Union' in love may coexist with 'insecurity'.

Gestures must therefore be read with the lyric's dramatic situation and modes of address rather than forced into mechanical categories.

Differences in the extent and method of description of women and men provide a useful critical indication. Reading beauty not merely as 'a body being seen' but as 'experience speaking' widens the scope of criticism.

The Production of Meaning in Bodily Description

To treat description from head to foot merely as sequential observation of the body would be too narrow. The selection of bodily details reveals the direction of the poetic gaze: where it pauses, how adjectives extend meaning, and which similes evoke extraordinary beauty or memories of familiar local objects. Bodily reference may convey intimacy, visual craft, or relationships of power. Its significance must be determined from the wording and speaker of the relevant lyric.

Youth and the Experience of Time

Descriptions of youth contain not only physical change but also an experience of time. Wonder at a new appearance, hesitation in self-awareness, caution concerning the social gaze, and the process of recognising oneself in the beloved's eyes construct the drama of youth. Such diversity resists treating female figures as a uniform image. When seasons change within a composition, temporal awareness acquires different social and emotional meanings; nature may support a relationship or intensify separation.

The Presence of Natural Beauty

Descriptions of flowers, forests, the moon, clouds, wind, or seasons take their meanings from the lyric's subject. An environment that seems joyous during fulfilled love may evoke sadness during separation. The change signifies more than the assertion that 'nature is sensitive': a character's inner state transforms the external order of symbols. A critical use of alambana and uddipana should mark this reversal of feeling.

From Description to Dialogue

An important question about the beauty of Vidyapati's love lyrics concerns the relationship between narrative presentation and dialogic longing. External description has limits; direct address by a character adds an answering voice. Through sequences of gazes, reticence, questions, and complaints, beauty ceases to be a static picture and becomes a changing relationship. Observing this movement can reduce the artificial division between outer physical beauty and inner emotional beauty.

Chapter Five: The Tradition of Poetics and the Beauty of Vidyapati's Poetry (pp. 303–428)

The Elements of Rasa

The contents refer to heroic, comic, and tranquil rasas alongside the states of union and separation in shringara. Studying rasa is not synonymous with

examining a character's private emotion; it entails analysing the artistic organisation of determinants, consequents, and transitory feelings.

Figures of Speech

The contents enumerate numerous figures, including utpreksha, upama, rupaka, yamaka, anuprasa, atishayokti, arthantaranyasa, virodhabhasa, vyatireka, drishtanta, nidarshana, samasokti, and paryayokti. The finest criterion for analysis is not simply naming a figure but examining its poetic function: visuality, sound, suggestion of meaning, and the intensification of emotion.

Classification of Heroines

The text presents numerous categories, among them mugdha, madhya, praudha, gupta, vidagdha, abhisarika, vasakasajja, manini, proshitapatika, virahotkanthita, vipralabdha, khandita, kalahantarita, svadhinapatika, parakiya, and kutani. A single lyric may bear the traces of more than one emotional state; the classification must therefore retain a measure of flexibility.

Verbal Ingenuity and the Suggestion of Meaning

Separate treatments of utterance and verbal ingenuity, symbolism, the construction of imagery, the theory of suggestion (dhvani), indirect expression, and enigmatic verse (drishtakuta) strengthen the book's attention to poetic craft. A threefold reading—of the surface meaning of words, their suggested meaning, and their cultural implications—is especially necessary in the case of drishtakuta.

Proverbs and Idioms

Colloquial Maithili, sayings, proverbs, and idioms connect Vidyapati's poetic language with the lives of ordinary people. A linguistic study must consider local meanings, phonetic patterning, contextual appropriateness, and the social position of the speaker.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

Rasa theory provides a disciplined framework for examining how feeling is generated in a literary work. Yet merely identifying a rasa does not explain the poetic process. The relations among vibhava, anubhava, sanchari-bhava, and sthayi-bhava must be demonstrated through the actual lines and words of a lyric. The success of the categories of rasa lies in their ability to accommodate the living diversity of readers' experiences.

The significance of simile, metaphor, alliteration, yamaka, or shlesha lies not in how many instances can be counted, but in what each device does in its particular context. One simile may diminish the distance between lovers while another increases it; sound patterning may intensify an emotion or generate irony.

Proverbs, idioms, and expressions drawn from popular speech are not merely ornaments: they carry cultural memory. Through them the living

speech of the people enters poetic language. The classical and the popular should be regarded not as adversaries but as traditions in active relation to one another.

The Textual Basis for Determining Rasa

The difficult work begins after the general principles of shringara rasa have been accepted. Which incident serves as the alambana, what kind of scene constitutes the uddipana, which gestures are anubhavas, and which momentary reactions are sanchari-bhavas? These are not questions answered simply by assigning technical labels. The same object may change its meaning from one line to the next. The poet's choice of words is decisive in constructing rasa. Critical analysis cannot therefore be considered complete after a mere enumeration of rasa categories.

Types of Figures of Speech and Their Functions

To name a device as simile or metaphor tells the reader how a comparison has been made. The more important question, however, is why the comparison has been made. In a scene of union, a simile may intensify intimacy; in separation, a comparable metaphor may sharpen the feeling of distance. Examining the movement produced by alliterative sounds, and the insistence created by repetition, reveals how figures of speech participate in the making of emotion.

Proverbs, Idioms, and the Rhythm of Song

Proverbs arise from the collective experience of speech communities. Poetry appropriates them and gives a general statement the meaning of a particular feeling. An idiom carries a social memory and an emotional inflection distinct from its literal sense. These forms of popular speech coexist with pauses, repetitions, and sound arrangements in lyrics intended for singing. A simple hierarchy between popular language and poetic ornament is consequently untenable.

Chapter Six: Vidyapati, the Uninhibited Singer of Shringara (pp. 429–474)

The Importance of Shringara

The psychological foundations of shringara, the relationship between beauty and love, and a threefold distinction among desire, beauty, and love provide the intellectual setting of this chapter. The term 'uninhibited' may be understood not merely as a transgression of convention but also as an outspoken poetic articulation of the experience of love.

Shringara in Union

The sequence of wounded pride, conciliation, a lover's secret journey, encounter, consummate union, and sexual intimacy presents the dramatic progression of love. The beauty of union does not always lie in an absence of expectation and fear; often it inheres in an encounter achieved after passing through precisely such states of mind.

Shringara in Separation

The contents list preliminary attraction, remembrance, praise of the beloved's qualities, longing, fainting, illness, agitation, delirious speech, numbness, madness, and states approaching death, together with distinctions such as pride within love, jealous resentment, absence on a journey, and sorrowful separation. These should be understood not as a literal catalogue of medical conditions but as a succession of experiences articulated through poetic rasa.

Radha and Krishna as the Objects of Love

A separate section on Radha and Krishna as the alambana of shringara provides the chapter's concluding thread. Rather than treating the emotional roles of Krishna and Radha as identical, one must attend to the ways in which each character's perspective and voice change in union and in separation.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

An interpretation of the adjective 'uninhibited' must begin by determining what it means: the fearless acceptance of the body, the spontaneous disclosure of feeling, or freedom from stylistic restraint? These three are not identical. Within the distinction between union and separation in shringara, pride, appeal, anticipation, memory, secrecy, and the apprehension surrounding a meeting represent different and subtle experiences.

It is not enough to define separation as the absence of union. Within memory, the absent beloved becomes increasingly present to the mind; a season or landscape that once stimulated desire may instead become a source of suffering. The beauty of poetic feeling emerges through this reversal.

Conclusion: An evaluation of shringara becomes more fruitful when it examines poetic strategy, emotional depth, and the arrangement of voices rather than offering moral praise or condemnation.

Instability Within Union

Not every image of union in shringara represents untroubled happiness. An anticipated meeting may be accompanied by fear, anxiety about public opinion, modesty, or the brevity of the time available. The experience of union is thus sometimes coloured by the possibility of separation. Such mixed states may fall outside rigid classifications; they make the poetry more vividly alive.

Memory and Time in Separation

Vipralambha should not be treated merely as an event of absence. Memory brings the missing beloved back into presence, yet that presence is not the equivalent of touch; it may itself become a source of pain. The seeming extension of daytime, the stillness of night, and the transformation of the seasons together produce the time experienced in separation. When the reader identifies temporal markers and reversals in the surrounding landscape, the inner craft of separation becomes clearer.

The Meaning of Uninhibited Expression

To call Vidyapati 'uninhibited' in the book's title and its chapter-level judgments is appealing; nevertheless, the word need not denote unrestrained sensual indulgence. Fearless mention of the body, direct expression of feeling, the spontaneous rhythms of folk song, and classical metaphors may all appear together in a poem. Examining uninhibited expression as a formal property, rather than as an occasion for moral accusation or defence, deepens the understanding of beauty.

Chapter Seven: The Emergence of Popular Consciousness in Vidyapati's Love Poetry (pp. 475–537)

Popular Consciousness and Popular Reality

The book raises questions concerning the dimensions of popular consciousness, the social responsibility of literature, healthy attitudes of mind, and domestic values. The representation of Radha and Krishna as figures of the people, together with linguistic references to ordinary life, narrows the distance between devotional narrative and lived social experience.

Satire of Social Evils

Opposition to child marriage, the portrayal of the go-between woman, and satire of social incongruities are explicitly identified as subtopics. In discussing them, it is essential to maintain an evidentiary distinction between the speech of a particular poetic character and general claims about historical society.

Folk Elements and the Tradition of Song

Drishtakuta, Maheshvani, and Nachari are included in the discussion of popular consciousness. These forms offer scope for studying the relationships among colloquial speech, faith, and song as performance. The circumstances in which a Maithili song is performed may alter the meaning of the lyric.

Vidyapati's Mithila

A separate discussion of Mithila's political, social, and cultural conditions (pp. 504–527) carries the book beyond purely internal literary criticism. Conclusions about historical events require corroboration from archival material or other reliable historical sources.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

Popular consciousness is not simply an inventory of rustic words. It is the poetic presence of labour, custom, festivals, women's relationships, family and household life, marriage practices, and collective memory. When a lyric affords glimpses of contemporary social behaviour, historians must use it with care: poetry is not a direct census of society.

In discussions of satire directed at social evils, the speaker's position is decisive. Is the satire the poet's own view, a character's complaint, or a convention of traditional humour? Without such distinctions, social judgments may become unreliable.

Maithili idioms, forms of address, the local cycle of seasons, and traditions of singing constitute this chapter's strongest possibilities. Treating the relationship between language and society as a means of producing meaning, rather than as mere decoration, deepens the book's engagement with popular life.

The Many Levels of Popular Consciousness

References to Mithila's popular life should not be reduced to a list of rural objects. Systems of address, exchanges among women, the cycle of seasons, domestic courtyards, traditional rites, humour, satire, and festivities all belong to popular consciousness. Language does more than name objects here: it also determines distance and intimacy in social relationships.

A Method for Examining Social Evils

To write the institutional history of a society directly from a joke or complaint in a poem is risky. Literature may express social tensions through exaggeration, folklore, or a character's private grievance. Serious inquiry into social evils requires independent corroboration from social history, law, ritual songs, and other contemporary writing.

The Conjunction of Folk and Classical Traditions

The easy repetition of folk melodies and the imagery of Sanskrit poetics need not stand in opposition. Local modes of address and conventional figures of speech may produce meaning together in a single lyric. This conjunction helps explain the breadth of Vidyapati's poetic appeal, although historical claims about his influence still require a distinct body of chronological evidence.

Chapter Eight: Vidyapati's Influence on Later Poets (pp. 539–568)

Mithila's Love of Poetry

The book treats Mithila's affection for poetry and its traditions of music and dance as an introduction to the history of literary influence. The later life of poetry develops not only in books but also in singing, ritual, and communal memory.

The Maithili Poetic Tradition

The relationship between Maithili poetry and Vidyapati, and his influence on Maithili poets, raises important questions of literary inheritance. Establishing 'influence' requires examining direct references, similarities of metre, language and imagery, and the possibility of chronological transmission.

Influence on Literature in Other Languages

The book expressly considers Vidyapati's influence upon poets working in Bengali and Brajabuli, Nepali, Assamese, Odia, and Bhojpuri. Rather than describing influence as transmission in one direction alone, it is especially

useful to examine textual transformation, regional traditions of singing, and reciprocal reception.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

Resemblance alone cannot establish influence. One must produce concrete comparative evidence concerning the later poet's period, the means by which texts circulated, metre, modes of address, the treatment of heroines, and shared arrangements of lyric lines. 'A love song resembling Vidyapati's' and 'a song inspired by Vidyapati' are two different propositions.

In Maithili and other traditions of song, four possibilities must be distinguished: direct imitation, creative transformation, transmission through folk singing, and participation in a common cultural tradition. Only after these distinctions have been made can the claim of influence acquire historical substance.

Evaluation: The chapter's importance lies in showing the enduring life of Vidyapati's work. Its further research potential resides in systematic comparisons of parallel lyric texts and scrutiny of manuscript traditions.

Imitation, Influence, and a Shared Tradition

The appearance of Radha and Krishna, the monsoon month of Sawan, separation, or a female confidante in the lyrics of two poets does not necessarily mean that the later poet drew directly upon Vidyapati. Such images may also belong to a widely shared cultural repertoire. Claims of direct influence require attention to chronology, textual circulation, distinctive turns of phrase, transmitters within traditions of singing, and comparison of available textual variants.

Transmission Across Languages

When examining the influence of Maithili songs on other languages, translated forms, phonetic adaptations of the original lyric, rhythmic recomposition, and the oral transformations introduced by folk singers must be recognised as different processes. Sometimes words remain unchanged; at other times the metaphor alters while the underlying emotional structure survives. Research should identify these transformations before determining the nature of influence.

The Independence of Later Poets

If the discussion of influence becomes solely a celebration of an earlier poet, the creativity of later writers is obscured. Poetic tradition consists of both reception and alteration. In a new language, before a new audience, and under changed social circumstances, the same conventions of shringara acquire new meanings. These changing meanings are themselves a subject of inquiry.

Chapter Nine: Conclusion (pp. 575–589)

Integrated Reflections

The book's intellectual journey begins with the philosophical foundations of love and beauty, and proceeds through psychological inquiry, the Radha–Krishna tradition, the classical classification of heroines, rasa and figures of speech, popular consciousness, and influence across languages. Throughout this progression, the chief characteristic of Vidyapati's poetry emerges as the interdependence of the experience of love and the beauty of language.

Possible Directions for Further Research

Studies of textual variants in individual lyrics, performance traditions, women's voices, local pronunciation, language contact, and the transmission of manuscripts would usefully extend the book's discussion. These are research directions proposed by the present critic, not verified quotations from the original book's conclusion.

The Structural Achievement of the Study

The nine-chapter arrangement makes the subject multidimensional. Its progression through philosophical and psychological foundations, categories of poetics, the social world of the people, and subsequent literary influence exemplifies a wide-ranging method of study.

The Interrelationship of Love and Beauty

Although the book begins by defining love and beauty under separate headings, its central chapters connect them as formative elements in one another. Physical attraction, the maturation of feeling, and artistic expression remain distinct but mutually influential dimensions.

The Uses and Limits of Classical Poetics

The vocabulary of rasa, figures of speech, classifications of heroines, and dhvani assists close reading; excessive classification, however, may obscure the particular voice of a lyric, its irony, satire, and social tensions. It is more appropriate to preserve the independence of the literary text alongside the classificatory scheme.

A Critical Rereading of Female Characters

Alongside extended descriptions of Radha's body, beauty, and gestures, her desire, dissent, voice, wounded pride, and separation should also occupy the centre of inquiry. The heroine then emerges not simply as the object of a masculine gaze but as a feeling and speaking subject.

Popular Life and Language

The presence of popular consciousness, idioms, Nachari, and Maheshvani reveals the importance of Maithili's social life. Investigating the mutual relationship between poetic form and linguistic practice would strengthen a historical reading of Vidyapati.

The Possibilities of Comparative Literature

The book's discussion of traditions in several languages is especially important. A comparative inventory of parallel lyric structures, translations, adaptations, melodic traditions, and later literary reception would make the study of influence more securely evidence-based.

Critical Extension and Close Reading

The book's conceptual, psychological, character-centred, poetic-theoretical, popular-cultural, and influence-oriented components are interconnected. An integrated conclusion should do more than declare Vidyapati to be 'a poet of love and beauty'. It should examine what kinds of love are given form, through which linguistic resources, and within which social circumstances and traditions of song.

A conclusion becomes more valuable when it distinguishes four things: its main propositions, the textual evidence for them, alternative interpretations, and the limitations of its findings. Problems of variant readings of Vidyapati's lyrics, poetic attribution, the historical character of his language, and women's voices hold particular importance for future scholarship.

Comprehensiveness and Breadth

The study extends from wide-ranging philosophical premises to poetics, social background, and later influence. Its breadth protects Vidyapati from the narrow identification of him as solely a 'poet of shringara'. Yet breadth does not in itself amount to depth. The more subjects a study includes, the greater the evidentiary discipline required for each conclusion. Clarifying the connections among the chapters is therefore a principal demand upon the conclusion.

Innovative Directions in the Reading of Poetry

Future research must attend equally to the analysis of lyric speakers, the heroine's desire and resistance, the singable structures of songs, linguistic textual variants, the cultural meanings of the vernacular, and historical evidence for influence. The questions raised here are critical proposals of the present study, not established conclusions of the author of the work under review. Maintaining this distinction helps readers understand the boundaries between established scholarship and renewed evaluation.

Overall Critical Assessment

A distinctive achievement of the book is its multilayered architecture. A framework extending from general theories of love to poetic form, characterisation, shringara, popular consciousness, and the study of influence offers readers a multidimensional introduction to Vidyapati's love poetry as a whole. This does not mean that all of its claims are beyond dispute; their scholarly validity must be assessed at different levels.

The central criterion of literary criticism is textual evidence. Here one must bring together words, sounds, the arrangement of lyric lines, speakers,

alambana and uddipana, social customs, and textual variants. The author's classifications provide a useful map; the map is not the territory itself. Every example needs interpretation in the light of its particular meaning.

Within traditional discourses of love and beauty, fresh readings are possible of female characters' agency, emotional resistance, social propriety, and conflicting desires. This is a critical proposal of the present study, not a direct quotation of the author's avowed position.

The theoretical comparison of Western aesthetics and Indian rasa theory is useful, but it would be inappropriate to erase their historical and cultural differences. The distinctive words and forms of Vidyapati's poetry, its traditions of singing, and Mithila's cultural references must remain at the centre of attention.

Integrated Conclusion

The active tension among language, society, and poetry in Agni-Shikha and Athato Kavya Jijnasa acquires a more systematic intellectual form in the critical essays of Pratham Purush. Popular consciousness gains artistic force not through declarations alone but through the organisation of imagery, style, rhythm, and the speaking position. The relationship between Mallick the poet and Mallick the critic becomes apparent in this dual undertaking.

Drama and Theatre: Nature and Models opens the performative dimension of this literary outlook. To write the history of Maithili drama, dramatic texts alone are insufficient; actual acting, institutions, audiences, songs, stage directions, and the social contexts of folk performance must also be considered. Literature becomes a communal experience at the moment when the written word acquires body, voice, and time upon the stage.

Mallick's discussion of love and beauty in Vidyapati turns attention towards the long historical inheritance of Maithili literature. Yet the conventional categories of shringara, rasa, figures of speech, and the classification of heroines should not become final judgments upon a poem. Questions concerning the speaker of love, women's experiences, vernacular language, lyrical expression, and transformation into later languages further enrich literary meaning.

The common conclusion arising from these five works is that cultural respect and independence of judgment must coexist in the criticism of Maithili literature. Mallick's poetry and criticism alike invite readers who recognise social inequality, possess discernment concerning beauty of form, and ask fresh questions within their own tradition. This sustained questioning gives rise to the ever-new possibilities of his literary work.

Expanded Bibliography

The principal works discussed in this book and relevant books on the subjects examined are listed below. The entries provide bibliographic details of books, editions, publishers, and publication years only; web references are excluded.

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APPENDIX: METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

The Nepal Bikram Samvat years cited have been converted to approximate CE years using the standard offset of BS minus 56–57 years. Web sources consulted include the Videha digital archive (videha.co.in). All URLs were last accessed April 2026. This research was prepared using primary texts, and standard academic resources. All quoted material is from the cited sources. For the most current scholarship, consult the Videha Parallel History series at www.videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm.

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